Murim Login

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Chapter 0

There's a Russian proverb:

> "Free cheese is only found in a mousetrap."

Looking back, I can't help thinking that everything about that day was someone's mousetrap. I'd been fired from the job I'd held for seven years, the weather was brutally hot, and I lived in a poor hillside neighborhood[1] you had to cross two hills to reach…

I'd barely made it up and was still catching my breath when I spotted it.

An old game capsule beneath a streetlamp.

What happened next? You can guess.

I'd become unemployed overnight. I was a hungry rat who couldn't possibly ignore the free cheese right in front of me.

Wouldn't someone have clapped and laughed as they watched me grunt and strain with the capsule on my back?

"The fool got caught in the trap!"

[1] *Daldongne*, literally "moon village," is a Korean term for a poor hillside neighborhood.

Chapter 1

"It's garbage."

Jinho delivered the verdict with the solemnity of a judge. He was the manager of the goshiwon[2] where I lived, a thirty-year-old exam candidate.

We were fairly close, being only three years apart, and he was always bragging about how much he knew about IT. That was why I'd shown him the capsule I'd picked up, but…

"Is it really that bad?"

"No. I said it's garbage."

Wow. Not even a hint of hesitation. For some reason, I felt personally insulted.

"You didn't even look at it properly."

Just as I'd said, he hadn't even looked inside. He'd merely given it a quick once-over, top to bottom, before declaring it garbage. Since I'd been wondering how much I could get for it secondhand, the blow hit me hard.

"Taekyung. Taekyung. Jin Taekyung. You're laboring under a serious misunderstanding."

"…?"

"Shit is shit. You don't have to dig through it to check for yesterday's bean sprouts. You can tell it's shit just by looking at it."

"Oh."

"Shh. Don't say anything more. I wasn't fishing for praise."

"Hyung…"[3]

I wanted to kill him. My fist trembled with the urge, and Jinho flinched. Unlike him, who had spent his entire life hunched over a desk, I had a fairly intimidating build.

"Taekyung. Let's recall Article 1, Clause 12 of the Awakened Persons Special Act. What you're about to do constitutes assault of a civilian by an Awakened…"

"I thought you said an F-rank Hunter like me didn't even count as an Awakened?"

"I did? When? Was I blackout drunk?"

Watching him make such a fuss, I could only sigh.

My fist slowly dropped.

"That's right. Good thinking. This field is small enough as it is. If word got around that you assaulted a civilian, you'd get fired from your Guild too…"

"I already got fired."

"Huh?"

---

[2] A goshiwon is a Korean residence of very small, inexpensive rented rooms, often with shared facilities.

[3] *Hyung* is what a younger man calls an older brother or a close older male friend.

“The moment I showed up, my Team Leader thanked me for all my hard work.”

I’d started that job at twenty. I’d needed to support my family in place of my late father, which was why I’d chosen to become a Hunter.

F-rank. The lowest possible grade, with no particular talent to speak of, but I prided myself on having worked hard. With what I earned, I paid for my mother’s medical treatment and supported my only younger sibling.

But now… it felt as though the past seven years had vanished all at once. I remembered the Team Leader’s impassive face as he informed me of my dismissal a few hours earlier, and my chest tightened.

“Uh… well.”

I gave a short laugh at Jinho’s flustered expression.

“You feel bad, don’t you?”

“Honestly… kind of.”

This guy. A serious expression really didn’t suit him.

“Then buy me a drink. This is when you’re supposed to act like my hyung.”[4]

“Listen to the disrespect on you. Try treating me like your hyung[5] before you say something like that.”

He said that, but still jerked his chin for me to follow. Judging by his expression, we were getting plastered tonight.

A Gate marks the boundary of the world. Outside it—in other words, in the modern world—is the civilized society we know. Go inside, though, and it’s crawling with monsters no one has ever seen or heard of.

The weakest and most common of them are goblins—even an F-rank Hunter like me can handle one.

The reason I’m bringing this up now is…

Gwaah. Gwaah.

How can a person even do that?

Was that thing human or a monster? Leaning against a utility pole and vomiting, Jinho looked just like a goblin that had taken a hard blow to the solar plexus.

“Hey, Jinho. Mr. Seong Jinho. Try to come to your senses.”

“Gwaah?”

…Just carry on.

I told you to drink slowly.

[4] *Hyung* is what a younger man calls an older brother or a close older male friend.
[5] *Hyung* is what a younger man calls an older brother or a close older male friend.

He'd been pounding drinks like a lunatic since the first round, and this was how he'd ended up. Never mind that I'd had to pay the bill—I was soaked through after carrying the dead-drunk man all the way back to the goshiwon.[6]

Sweat came standard. Vomit was an optional extra. There was no question whose mouth it had come from.

With his intermittent retching as background music, I watched the sun sink toward the horizon.

Getting fired wasn't bad enough. Fuck.

The memories of the day flashed through my mind like a panorama.

What a spectacular day.

"Urp. Urrrgh. Where are we, driver? Huh?"

And you were the highlight of it all.

"We're home. We're here, so try to wake up."

"Home? My home's in Gangwon Province. Oh, Mom. Mom! I want some of my mom's doenjang stew.[7]"

"Oh, for crying out loud. It's the goshiwon,[8] hyung."[9]

"The goshiwon?[10] Hope Goshiwon?"[11]

"Yeah. So try to wake up."

"Hope… Right. Hope can't be bought with money. My mom always said it was in everyone's heart. She makes incredible doenjang stew.[12]"

I waited patiently until he reached the part about doenjang stew, then punched him in the gut.

Even while vomiting, he mumbled Article 1, Clause 12 of the Awakened Persons Special Act, proving that he was, in fact, an exam candidate.

"I still feel filthy."

I went straight to the goshiwon's[13] shower room and washed for thirty minutes, but I could still smell vomit clinging to the tip of my nose.

When I returned to my room, sniffing all the way, two nuisances were waiting for me.

---

[6] A goshiwon is a Korean residence of very small, inexpensive rented rooms, often with shared facilities.

[7] *Doenjang* is Korean fermented soybean paste, used here as the base of a stew.

[8] A goshiwon is a Korean residence of very small, inexpensive rented rooms, often with shared facilities.

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[12] *Doenjang* is Korean fermented soybean paste, used here as the base of a stew.

[13] A goshiwon is a Korean residence of very small, inexpensive rented rooms, often with shared facilities.

Gwaah…

One was Jinho, dead drunk, and the other was…

“Oh, I forgot about this.”

The capsule. I’d left the refrigerator-sized thing in my room, barely three pyeong,[14] and it felt as though it took up the entire space. I retreated onto the bed and began wondering what to do with it.

Should I take it back and throw it away?

I could hand it over to a scrap dealer instead. What were scrap-metal prices like these days? It weighed at least fifty kilograms,[15] so I could probably get enough for a few snacks.

I thought it was a fairly useful piece of equipment.

Shit, huh? Was it really that much of a piece of junk?

Come to think of it, I hadn’t even looked inside. Curiosity got the better of me, and I began examining the capsule.

“First, the exterior is… not great.”

The capsule’s surface was stained yellow with nicotine or something, and rust seemed to have formed in places. Once I set aside my attachment and took a proper look, I understood what Jinho had meant.

“Is this how you open it?”

I pressed the lone protruding button, and the lid opened to reveal the interior. I’d expected something impressive, but there was nothing much to see after all.

There was only an ergonomically designed chair for extended play and a VR helmet that enclosed the entire head… Huh?

“What’s this? An instruction manual?”

More precisely, it was a small booklet labeled *Product User Manual*.

Did people really leave instruction manuals inside things they were throwing away? Especially junk like this?

Curious, I opened to the first page.

> **Product User Manual**
> **Product name:** Virtual Reality Interface
> **Model:** ARK-2020
> **Manufacturer:** H Soft
> **Manufacturing date:** January 1, 2020

I skimmed the print without much thought until my eyes stopped on the manufacturing date.

---

[14] A pyeong is a Korean unit of area, about 3.31 square meters (35.6 square feet).

[15] Fifty kilograms is about 110 pounds.

January 1, 2020. It had to be a printing error. Surely.

What kind of lunatic would have been making a game machine on that day—no, during that period?

That period was the Great Cataclysm.

January 1, 2015. Humanity received more than a New Year's sunrise.

Gates—or dungeons, as they were also called—began appearing all over the world, and monsters no one had ever seen or heard of poured through them.

Monsters and Awakened. War and destruction…

The unreal invaded reality, and the Great War, unlike any in Earth's history, ended only with the death of the monsters' lord, the Demon King Asmodeus.

That day was January 1, 2020. It was known as Victory Day.

So there's no way this can be right.

I clicked my tongue and turned the page.

> **Warning**
>
> - The player cannot log out at will.
> - If the player dies during gameplay, resurrection is impossible.

Ah, I see. I nodded and lay down on the narrow mattress. There were still a few pages left, but who cared?

"I should get some sleep."

I'd be better off sleeping than reading some deranged instruction manual. I pushed Jinho into a corner and closed my eyes.

Gwaah. Gwaah.

"…"

Gwaah. Gwaah.

"…"

Did that capsule have a soundproofing function?

The chair was hard. It had been made in 2020, so it was the same age as me. The chair was a youthful twenty-seven. Its cushion had gone flat long ago.

I took comfort in the fact that it didn't smell and pulled the blanket up to my neck.

Gwaah. Gwaah.

…I even put on the VR helmet.

Wearing something like this is going to make my neck hurt.

That minor complaint vanished the moment I put on the helmet. A world of complete silence. Not so much as a whisper of noise.

But what followed wasn't sleep. It was thought.

What am I going to do tomorrow?

Hunters were certainly well paid, but that depended on their rank.

F-rank Hunters like me were a dime a dozen, and unless you belonged to a Guild, you had to report to a day-labor agency before dawn.

Being unaffiliated was miserable. Government policy was never kind to unaffiliated Hunters, and the punishing tax rates imposed on Hunters were enough to leave you breathless just hearing about them.

So now I'm one of them.

Unlike me, my mother and younger sister lived in an apartment in a Safety Sector. It was an extravagant expense on an F-rank Hunter's income, but nothing mattered more to me than my family's safety.

Until now, I had barely managed to scrape together enough money for each annual renewal of their jeonse lease.[16] But from now on… who knew?

Fuck. I don't know.

I suddenly thought of my late father.

He had devoted himself to his family and was respected by society, but he died when I was seven.

A monster attack caused by a Gate breach. As an ordinary office worker, he probably never had a chance.

If my father were still by my side, could he have shown his son which way to go?

I've still done my best all this time. Please believe in me.

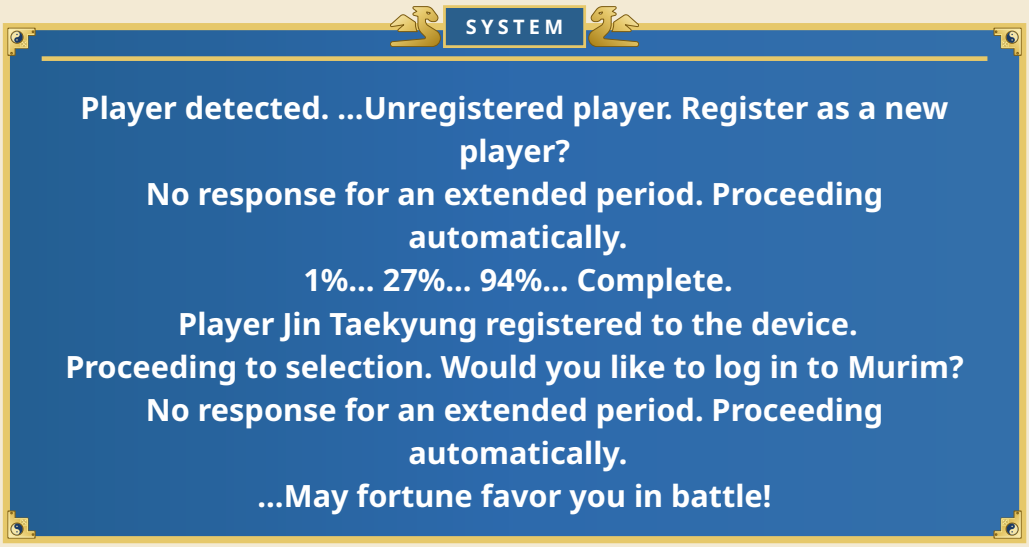
Maybe the alcohol was finally catching up with me, or maybe it was because I was thinking about the past. Without realizing it, my body went slack and my eyes began to close.

As I surrendered to the wave of drowsiness washing over me, I thought:

I hope things will be a little better when I open my eyes.

Someone's voice pierced my ears, but I didn't care anymore. I slipped gently into sleep.

[16] A jeonse lease is a Korean rental secured by a large refundable deposit instead of monthly rent.


SYSTEM
Player detected. ...Unregistered player. Register as a new player?
No response for an extended period. Proceeding automatically.
1%... 27%... 94%... Complete.
Player Jin Taekyung registered to the device.
Proceeding to selection. Would you like to log in to Murim?
No response for an extended period. Proceeding automatically.
...May fortune favor you in battle!

Chapter 2

A cold wind brushed my face.

I'd been sensitive to the cold since I was a kid, so I kept my windows closed all year round. Who had opened the window, then?

Obviously.

Seong Jinho, my mortal enemy.

Grumbling, I pulled the blanket up to my neck. The woman lying beside me let out a soft whine.

"…Huh?"

A woman? What woman?

I woke in an instant and shot upright like a soldier hearing the wake-up signal. Then I slowly turned my head.

"Tài lěng le.[17]"

Good lord. I was stunned twice over. First, because I couldn't make sense of the situation. Second, because the woman lying beside me was unbelievably beautiful.

She kept muttering words I couldn't understand as she burrowed deeper beneath the blanket. Even in my dazed state, she was beautiful enough to make my heart skip a beat.

If that cold wind hadn't blown in right then, I might have stared at her for quite a while.

But where am I?

I looked around. Red candlelight glowed softly through the room. A strangely provocative fragrance filled the air, and a beautiful woman lay beside me, covering her naked body with a blanket.

A place I'd never visited but had heard plenty about.

A room salon?[18]

But why was I here?

I was completely bewildered. What had happened? Yesterday, I'd had a drink with Jinho hyung[19] and returned to my room at the goshiwon.[20]

I clearly remembered climbing into the capsule to escape Jinho's thunderous snoring.

Am I dreaming?

I pinched my forearm hard. It hurt. This wasn't a dream.

---

[17] *Tài lěng le* is Mandarin Chinese for "It's too cold."

[18] A room salon is a Korean private-room entertainment venue where customers are served food, alcohol, and conversation by hostesses.

[19] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[20] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive single rooms, often rented by students or people living alone.

The situation grew more baffling by the second. After staring blankly around the room, I grabbed the woman by the shoulder and shook her.

“Excuse me?”

The woman peered at me through half-lidded eyes. Her irises shimmered dark blue, and my heart began pounding again.

“Who are you?”

“Shenme?”

“Ah, Ms. Sunmi. But that wasn’t what I meant…”

“Shenme?”

“…Yes?”

“Shenme…?”

What the hell is this?

For a moment, we stared at each other in silence. Then I realized it. This woman wasn’t Korean.

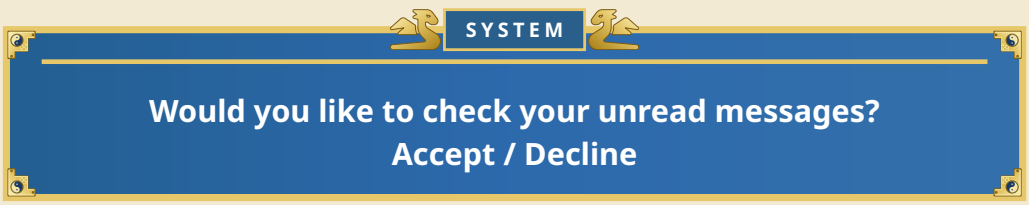
“Are you Chinese? Or Filipino?”

“…Zhōngguó rén ma?”

This is useless. We can’t communicate at all.

I scratched vigorously at the back of my head in frustration. The next moment, I sprang up like a coiled spring.

Ding.



A bell rang from somewhere.

A square window floated in midair like a ghost.

I had no idea where it had come from—or, more importantly, why I could see something like this. Goose bumps prickled across my skin.

“What the fuck is this?”

I lashed out on reflex, forcing the words through clenched teeth.

My fist pierced the square window—or rather, passed through it. More precisely, it passed through the word *Accept*.

Ding.

SYSTEM

No response for an extended period. Randomly selecting a character.
Searching Murim... Beginning play as character Jin Taekyung!
Logged in to Murim.
First-login rewards will be granted.
The player's current language can be changed. Apply the Integrated Language Pack?

A character? Murim? Login?

"Huh? Huh?"

SYSTEM

Applying the Integrated Language Pack.

"Wait, hold on!"

That was when the woman spoke.

"Young Master Jin. Are you feeling ill?"

She was speaking perfect Korean. I looked back and forth between the square window announcing that the Integrated Language Pack had been applied and the woman, then thought:

What the hell is going on?

Wolhwa. That was the woman's name.

She had smooth, pale skin and a tiny face—no bigger than my fist. Her delicate features were perfectly arranged, and her eyes were so large and clear that she could have put a celebrity to shame.

I marveled at her all over again.

The graphics are incredible.

By then, I'd already worked out the general situation. Once I put a few things together, the truth was simple.

Murim. Character. Login. Play. The last place I'd fallen asleep was inside a game capsule. And most importantly—

SYSTEM

Would you like to open the message window?
Accept / Decline

There was a System window. I could issue commands aloud or in my head. Scratching my head acted as a kind of shortcut. I could even click the options I wanted in midair.

The more I see, the more amazing this gets.

It was a far cry from the last game I'd played, but this was a game. I was playing a game right now.

But when did I log in?

I didn't remember plugging anything in. Just as I was trying to recall what had happened the night before, Wolhwa suddenly held out a bowl full of water in her spotless hands.

"Drink. You don't seem fully awake yet."

The AI is incredible, too.

I stole glances at Wolhwa's face as I drank the water, then started in surprise.

What the hell?

The cold water slid down my throat, cooling me all the way to my stomach. The sensation was so vivid that goose bumps rose on my forearms.

The lifelike graphics and the NPC's artificial intelligence were one thing, but even a sip of cold water felt too real for this to be a game.

Wow. I'd heard that technology had advanced by leaps and bounds, but I never imagined it had come this far. Now I understood why people became gaming addicts.

So this is why everyone goes on about virtual reality.

I looked around with my mouth hanging open like a kindergartener at an amusement park. Then acrid smoke rose from somewhere and obscured my view.

I turned my head. Wolhwa was watching me intently, a long-stemmed tobacco pipe already between her lips.

"Why…?"

She seemed so much like a real person that I slipped into polite speech without thinking. Of course, the fact that she was stunningly beautiful had something to do with it.

Wolhwa exhaled a stream of smoke and answered.

"Just because. I wanted to see you?"

I thought she was just a pretty face, but she had one hell of a presence, too.

If a bunch of high school girls saw her, they'd be screaming "Big Sis!" while blood poured from both nostrils. From head to toe, she practically had one phrase written all over her.

Femme fatale.

They really nailed her character concept. Plenty of players probably start the game just for Wolhwa.

“Young Master Jin, do you know you’ve been acting strange today?”

Young Master Jin? What an embarrassing way to be addressed.

Still, I pretended not to notice. Somehow, I wanted to enjoy the situation a little.

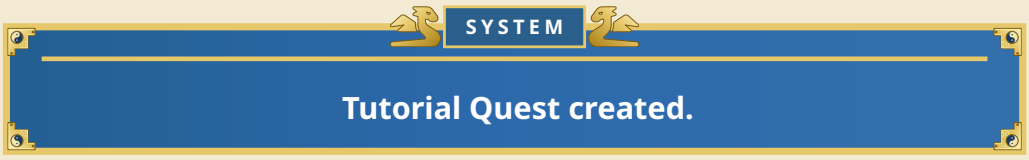
It’s a game, after all.

“What do you mean?”

“Everything? You keep staring into empty air as if you’ve lost your mind, and now you’re suddenly speaking formally. I can’t make heads or tails of you.”

The instant Wolhwa finished speaking—

Ding.



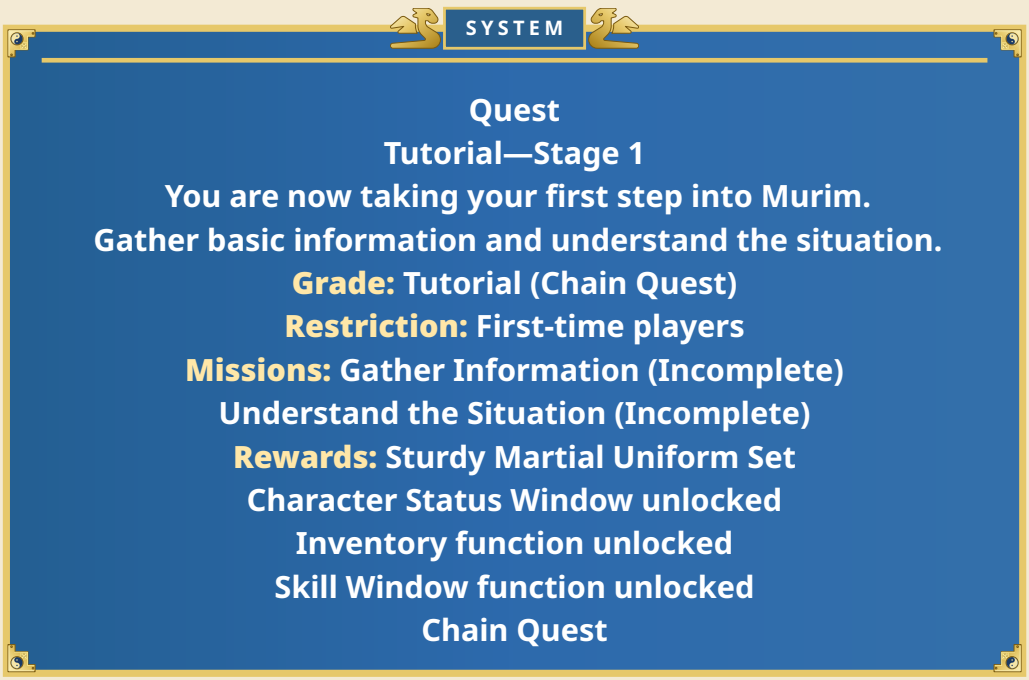
The way this game unfolds is pretty innovative.

Usually, games started with something like, “At last, you’re awake,” before immediately handing out a tutorial quest.

Is this what they call freedom?

Uh… Check quest?

Even as I thought it, I wasn’t sure whether that was the right command. But with the familiar sound effect, a quest window appeared at once.



Gather information? Understand the situation?

I hadn’t played many games, but I’d never seen a quest like this before.

Usually, they had you kill a few rabbits or practice using the game interface.

Still, I had to give it a try.

“How much do you know about me?”

Even I thought it was a blunt question. I could see Wolhwa smiling through the tobacco smoke.

“That’s an interesting question. Should I say you’re just like the rumors?”

“Rumors?”

“The stories you already know so well, Young Master. They aren’t exactly flattering enough to tell you to your face.”

“That’s fine. Let’s hear them.”

I was growing more interested in this game by the minute. It was the first game I’d played in a long time, but more than that, its approach was refreshingly different from the usual. Whoever had made it knew how to build a game.

“I’m just curious whether they match the rumors I’ve heard. It’s not like this has only been going on for a day or two. Why would I get offended?”

“…If you insist.”

She took the bait.

I smiled inwardly, pleased. Now all that remained was to pry out some real information.

“First. Do you know who I am?”

It was an even stranger question than the one before, but Wolhwa answered without hesitation. She almost seemed to be enjoying the situation, too.

“The youngest son of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who turned twenty this year. Surely I don’t need to tell you his name as well?”

I answered confidently.

“I know. Jin Taekyung.”

My name is Jin Taekyung. I’m the youngest son of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

At my confident reply, Wolhwa choked in the middle of exhaling smoke.

“Second. What kind of place is the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

After barely managing to stop coughing, Wolhwa answered.

“They have a good reputation among the people. From time to time, they wipe out bands of mounted bandits, and when droughts come, they distribute relief grain before even the magistrate’s office does.”

That’s it?

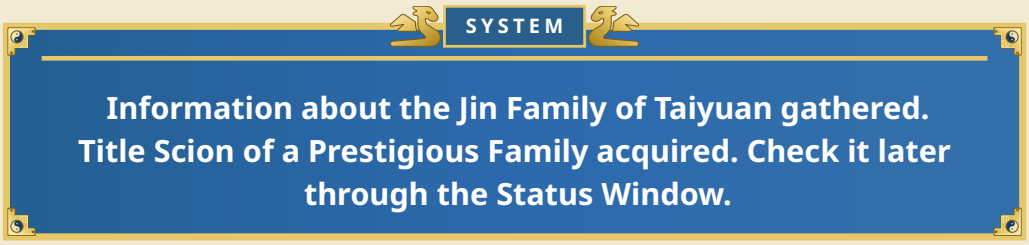
As if she had noticed my disappointment, Wolhwa continued.

“More than anything, they’re a prestigious family representing Shanxi Province. You could call them an old tree with deep roots.”

“Oh!”

I let out an involuntary exclamation—not because I was moved by the greatness of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, but because of the System notification.

Ding.



A title? Scion of a Prestigious Family?

I guessed it was something like a title in a fantasy game.

Dragon Slayer, or something like that.

You received one after accomplishing a certain feat, and equipping it granted additional effects. In that respect, I had to say I was pretty lucky.

This guy really was born with a silver spoon in his mouth.

Being born into a prestigious family counted as an achievement. It pissed me off and made me happy at the same time. That meant the random character selected against my will had turned out to be a lottery winner. But the story didn't end there.

"I've heard there are problems inside and outside the family these days."

"Problems? What kind of problems?"

Come to think of it, the quest window's information-gathering mission was still marked *Incomplete*. That meant there was more information to collect.

"Externally, there's the conflict with the Mount Heng Sword Sect, which is constantly eyeing the position of Alliance Leader in Shanxi Province. Internally…"

Wolhwa leisurely tapped the ash from her pipe.

"I hear that family's third son is a notorious good-for-nothing."

"Ah. There's always one of those wherever you go."

I nodded unconsciously, then was seized by a strange feeling.

"Excuse me."

"Yes?"

"I'm only asking as a joke, but how many sons does the Jin Family of Taiyuan have?"

She answered with a sunny smile.

"Three."

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had three sons, and I was the youngest of them. But the third son was a notorious good-for-nothing. Which meant—

Fuck. That's me, isn't it?

Ding.

SYSTEM

Title Shame of the Family acquired. Check it later through the Status Window.
Gather Information complete.

I couldn't decide whether to laugh or cry. Then I saw Wolhwa snickering and let out a hollow laugh myself.

Fine. No point getting worked up. So what if I'm the shame of the family? It's only a game, anyway.

I opened the quest window and confirmed that *Gather Information* had changed to *Complete*.

The problem is understanding the situation.

This damn quest was so vague that I had no idea what exactly it wanted. In the end, was Wolhwa my only solution?

"Where are we?"

"Honghwaru, the finest pleasure house in Shanxi. This is my room."

Through our conversation, I learned a few more miscellaneous facts.

We were in Honghwaru, located in the heart of Taiyuan. Wolhwa was a fairly high-ranking courtesan, and she and I had spent the night… Ahem.

Despite all the various things we discussed, no System notification appeared. Eventually, I ran out of questions to ask.

At the very end, I was reduced to asking this:

"What's my situation right now?"

Wolhwa sighed.

"Young Master Jin, I'm sorry to say this, but you seem a little crazy right now. How about getting some rest?"

Yeah. I feel like I'm going crazy, too.

As sunlight streamed through the window, I began to wonder what on earth I was doing.

This isn't some kind of mystery game.

The graphics and artificial intelligence were all great, but getting stuck on the tutorial had completely drained the fun out of it. If there was one thing I'd learned, it was that the capsule I'd found yesterday was a much better piece of equipment than it looked.

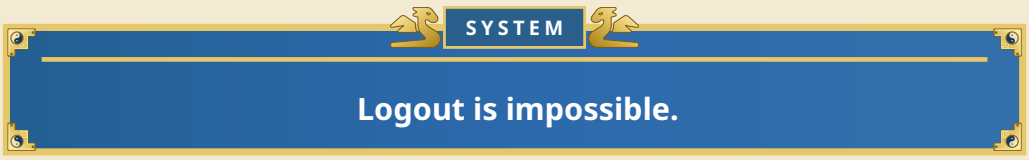
A game this advanced had to require serious hardware, yet I hadn't experienced a single bit of lag. It should sell for a decent price on the used market.

I need to start looking for a new job today, too.

Still, the game hadn't been bad for the little while I'd played it.

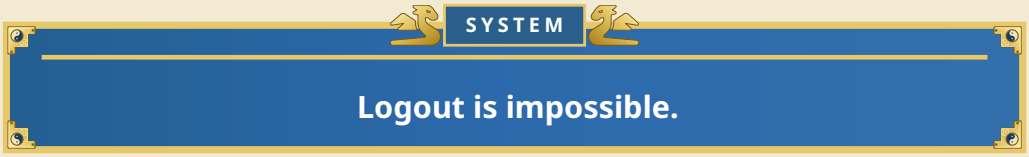
I gave Wolhwa a final nod and shouted:

“Log out!”



Huh?

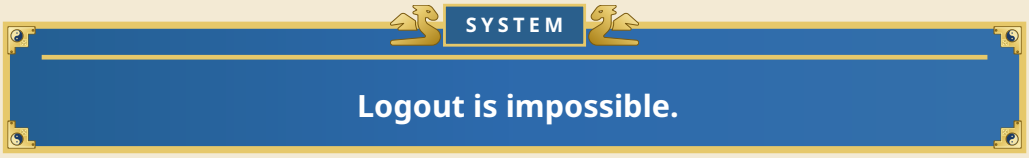
“Log out.”



What’s going on?

An error? Or had the piece-of-junk capsule finally started lagging?

“…Log out?”



There was no doubt about it. Error or lag, the damn junk capsule had finally caused trouble. I tried ten more times after that, but every attempt failed.

By this point, my anger had gradually turned into worry and regret.

Is something bad going to happen to me?

I shouldn’t have picked it up just because it was free. I should have thrown it away the moment Jinho called it garbage. Or at least the moment I read that insane instruction manual…

No. Wait.

The instruction manual. That was right—I’d read it. More precisely, I’d read a few of the warnings before tossing it aside, but I had read them.

What did they say?

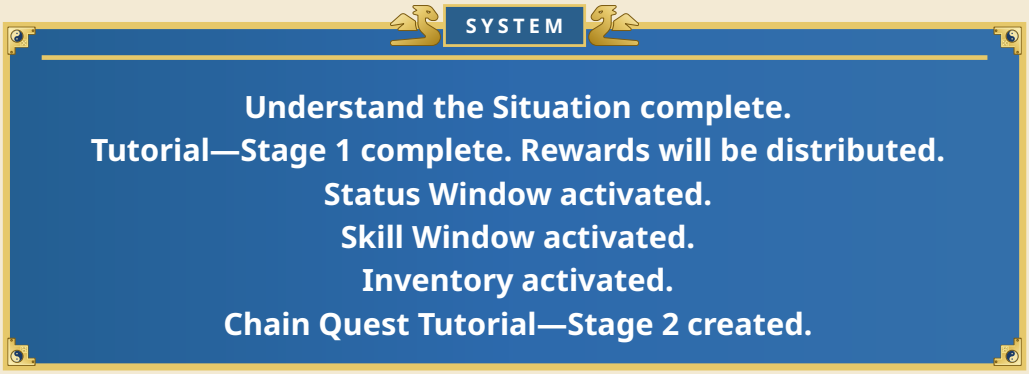
The moment I finally remembered every warning I’d managed to read, a chill ran through my entire body.

> **Warning**
>
> - The player cannot log out at will.
> - If the player dies during gameplay, resurrection is impossible.

I’m trapped inside the game? Me?

The System notification answered my question for me.

Ding.



At that moment, a single thought filled my head.

I’m fucked.

Chapter 3

A young man’s reflection shimmered on the calm surface of the water.

Dark eyebrows. Sharp, well-defined features. When he lifted the corners of his mouth, deep dimples appeared. But the forced smile vanished as if washed away the very next moment.

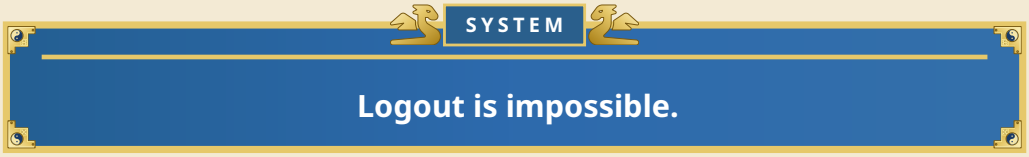
Crash.

I hurled the dish of wash water to the floor, sending shards flying in every direction.

“Fuck! Fuuuck!”

What good was being handsome if I couldn’t log out?

I’d spent the past three days raging and raising hell, but the answer never changed.



What kind of lunatics would make something like this?

I continued hurling curses as I recalled the warnings.

> **Warning**
>
> - The player cannot log out at will.
> - If the player dies during gameplay, resurrection is impossible.

In short, it was simple.

I was playing a martial-arts game called *Murim*, but I couldn’t log out whenever I wanted—and if my character died, so would I.

Ha. Ha. Ha.

What kind of bullshit is this?

And yet, it was really happening.

I couldn’t log out. I’d spent three days waiting for someone outside to rescue me, but nothing had happened. I hadn’t tested the part about dying, but judging by the circumstances, it was probably true too.

But there is a way.

If “the player cannot log out at will” was the wording, that implied logging out might become possible after meeting certain conditions.

For example, completing a quest or leveling up.

That was the answer I'd arrived at because this place, *Murim*, was a game.

Games rewarded you whenever you completed a quest or leveled up. Completing Tutorial—Stage 1 had already proved that much.

For now, I'll focus on quests and leveling up.

That was the conclusion I'd reached after three days of thinking. And it came with one essential requirement: survival.

I had to operate somewhere my life wouldn't be in danger. If I could get someone's help too, even better.

As it happens, I know exactly the right place.

Just then, Wolhwa's voice drifted in from outside the door.

"Young Master Jin, the carriage is ready."

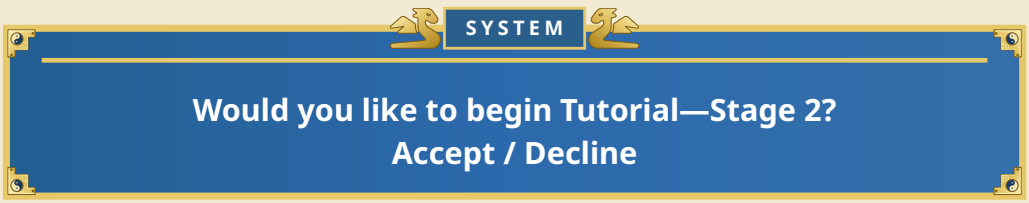
It was a carriage to take Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan home—not F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung.

The four-horse carriage Wolhwa—or rather, Honghwaru[21]—had provided was large and extravagant.

The coachman kept to himself and never said a word to me. That was fine by me.

I didn't want anyone bothering me right now.

Check the quest.



I'd opened this quest window dozens of times over the past three days, only to close it again. I'd been afraid of the unknown. But I wasn't hesitating anymore.

Accept.

Ding.

[21] Honghwaru is a pleasure house in Taiyuan.

SYSTEM

Quest
Tutorial—Stage 2
You have familiarized yourself with the basic information and situation.
But Murim is an unpredictable place. From this point on, use the only power unique to you: the System.
Grade: Tutorial (Chain Quest)
Restriction: First-time player
Objective: Check and Distribute Status Window Points (Incomplete)
Check and Distribute Skill Window Points (Incomplete)
Check and Equip Inventory Items (Incomplete)
Reward: Sharp Spear
Chain Quest

If that was all it wanted, I could have finished it ages ago. Then again, maybe this was the obvious next step.

No matter how strange things were, this place was still a game at its core.

I thought back to the online games I'd played once in a blue moon.

Check the Status Window.

SYSTEM

Status Window
LV. 10 Jin Taekyung
Occupation: Third Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 0
Titles: Scion of a Prestigious Family / Shame of the Family (Title effects active)
Strength: 10 **Stamina:** 10
Agility: 10 **Intelligence:** 10
Charm: 10 **Internal Energy:** 10 years
Unassigned Points: 100
- Distribute your unassigned points.
- Scion of a Prestigious Family (All stats +5, Fame +50)
- Shame of the Family (All stats −5, Fame −50)

What the hell is this?

I blinked. I felt completely blindsided.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was a major power in the area. And this guy was even from one of Murim's great families…but he was only Level 10, a third-rate martial artist?

Is this for real?

My neck grew stiff as I read the special notes.

The effect of the Scion of a Prestigious Family title was completely canceled out by Shame of the Family.

I was an idiot for getting my hopes up.

A rich wastrel born into a good family, neglecting martial arts training while drowning in women and alcohol. No wonder they called him the shame of the family.

I'm screwed.

But there were no take-backs. I'd just have to suck it up and move on.

The one silver lining was that all my stats had been reset. Being able to raise the stats I wanted was a huge advantage.

I scrutinized the Status Window.

This isn't just a game. Think. Think, think…

I couldn't treat this place as an ordinary game.

My life was on the line. If I dumped everything into Strength or Agility like I had in the RPGs I played as a student, I'd be dead in no time.

Then something caught my eye.

Should I invest in Internal Energy?

Internal energy, or inner power.

It was another name for the kind of qi—mana or aura—that high-ranking Hunters used in the real world.

In most martial-arts novels, old geezers with one foot in the grave could chew up, tear apart, savor, and enjoy vigorous young masters—all because they possessed enormous internal energy.

Martial arts meant internal energy. And when you thought of a master, you thought of a master of internal energy. There was a reason people called internal energy the yardstick of a martial artist's strength.

I'll be cautious for now…one point into Internal Energy.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Internal Energy can only be increased through training and items such as elixirs.

Right. I knew that would happen. I hadn't gotten my hopes up at all.

...Damn this System.

Then Internal Energy is out.

That left five stats.

Strength, Stamina, Agility, Intelligence, and Charm.

I decided to exclude Intelligence and Charm.

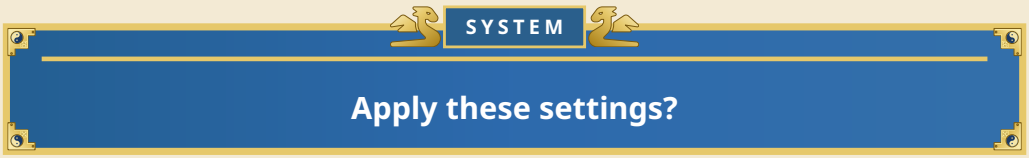
They won't help me.

My goal was survival and logging out—not taking the college entrance exam or dating.

Fortunately, I was a professional Hunter with seven years of experience, and I knew exactly what was needed to stay alive.

Thirty points each into Strength and Stamina. Forty into Agility.

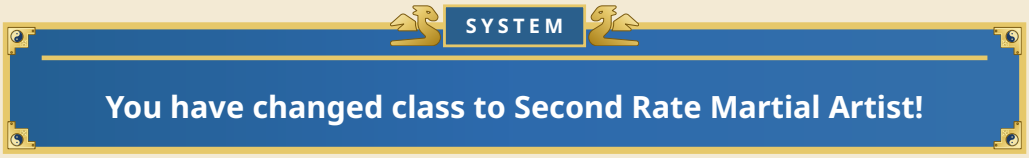
I'd reached that decision after careful thought. That gave me decent strength and stamina, along with excellent evasiveness. It was also the fighting style I'd grown accustomed to over the past seven years.



Yes.

That was when it happened.

Ding.



One hundred points in total.

As the number of unassigned points vanished, I felt the System's power seep through me from head to toe, reaching even the unseen depths of my body. It connected. Gathered. Loosened.

For an instant, heat swept through my body as if I'd swallowed the sun. Only after the lingering warmth faded could I finally open my eyes.

And then I was stunned.

"Th-this..."

My voice trembled despite myself. Not from the shock of an unfamiliar sensation, but because a feeling I'd experienced only once long ago—one I could never forget—had come rushing back.

How could I forget? That day, seven years ago.

Awakening...!

The sensation had come without warning, leaving my twenty-year-old self completely helpless.

When I opened my eyes again, I realized that I had been chosen. One of the chosen 0.1 percent. I had become an Awakened.

Remembering the exhilaration I'd felt that day only made me more confused now.

"Why is this happening here?"

The System notification snapped me out of my turmoil.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Check and Distribute Status Window Points complete.

I licked my parched lips and thought.

Right. Focus on the present for now. There are only two things left before Tutorial—Stage 2 is complete.

Check the Skill Window.

SYSTEM

Skill Window
LV. 10 Jin Taekyung
Cultivation Technique: Jin Family's Cultivation Technique (Unavailable)
Martial Arts: Jin Family's Spear Technique / Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique (Unavailable)
Muscles and Bones: 10
Sinews and Meridians: 10
Unassigned Points: 100

- **Distribute your unassigned points.**
- **Martial arts cannot be used.**
- **You have forgotten the formula because you have not trained in martial arts for a long time.**

Opening the Skill Window had been a good idea. The moment I saw it, every stray thought vanished and post-nut clarity hit me.

One, two, three.

Had I counted wrong? Or were the letters too small for me to see? I widened my eyes and stared at the Skill Window.

One, two, three…and three.

The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, the Jin Family's Spear Technique, and the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique. Those were all the skills Jin Taekyung—or rather, I—had. And apparently, I'd forgotten every one of them.

This is driving me insane.

If I died, the cause would be pent-up rage. Pure pent-up rage.

Only after calming down somewhat could I look at the Skill Window with a clear head.

Right. I could always learn more martial arts later.

At least I have unassigned points.

Trying to comfort myself with that thought, I looked at the Skill Window again. Maybe because it was so empty, two terms immediately caught my eye.

Muscles and Bones. Sinews and Meridians. I've seen those a lot in martial-arts novels.

Sinews and Meridians referred to tendons and blood vessels, while Muscles and Bones meant the muscles and skeletal frame.

In other words, Sinews and Meridians were for an internal-energy-focused build, while Muscles and Bones were for external martial arts. I decided to lean a little more toward Muscles and Bones.

The reason was simple.

I'll have a better chance of surviving if I choose what I'm already familiar with.

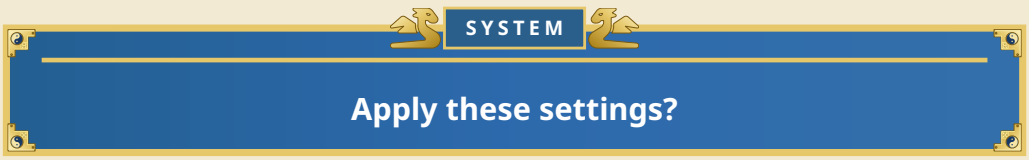
In the real world, I was an F-rank Hunter. In Murim terms, I was a third-rate martial artist, or maybe even worse.

Magic and aura… I'd seen them with my own eyes, but using them myself was out of the question. I couldn't even dream of it.

You're always better at something you've done before.

You had to have used internal energy before to know how to use it. The way I'd fought over the past seven years was closer to that of an external martial artist.

Sixty into Muscles and Bones. Forty into Sinews and Meridians.



Yes. Apply.

This time, what swept through me was nothing like the exhilaration I'd felt from the Status Window. If anything, it was pain. I could hear the bones deep inside my body twisting.

Urgh.

Seconds? Minutes? I had no idea. When the pain passed, all that remained was my ragged breathing—and the reward for enduring it.

My physique…

It had changed. My shoulders had broadened by half a span, and muscle had hardened across my chest and back. The silk clothes that had felt a little loose now felt constricting.

When I clenched my fist, I felt strength and springiness I hadn't been able to sense before. I'd grown stronger. It was an experience I'd never had in the real world.

Because there's no System there.

I could build strength, stamina, and flexibility through training in the real world, but until I underwent a measurement, I could only sense the changes vaguely.

But Murim was different.

I could see my abilities through the Status Window and improve the ones I needed. I didn't know where the endpoint was, but I could keep moving forward.

I'll get stronger. And I'll survive.

I'd fought countless monsters over the past seven years. Some days I'd returned without a scratch; other days I'd barely escaped with my life.

F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung had something Murim's Jin Taekyung didn't: experience. And desire.

Stronger, stronger, stronger. And survive.

Just as I clenched my fist and made that vow, another notification rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Check and Distribute Skill Window Points complete.

Only one thing remained.

Check the Inventory.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Inventory
Sturdy Martial Uniform Set
Grade: Third Rate
Restriction: None
Effect: None
Description: Made from light, durable cloth. Suitable for beginners.

The description was simple, befitting a basic item.

Equip item.

A cool sensation swept over my entire body, and I found myself dressed in a black martial uniform.

It wasn't just my clothes that had changed. A headband—commonly called a hero's headband in martial-arts novels—was tied firmly around my forehead, and I was wearing leather shoes instead of silk ones.

Did I at least look like a run-of-the-mill martial artist now?

Store item.

The moment I thought about storing the silk clothes I'd taken off, they vanished from my hands.

An Inventory. This is incredibly convenient. It might even be useful in combat, depending on how I used it.

Having an Inventory would make raids so much easier.

With one of these, I could hang back and collect Magic Gems without even fighting the monsters. I'd make enough in a year to put up a whole building.

But that's not going to happen.

Because this was a game. Once I logged out, it would all be over.

...Though I wasn't even sure I'd survive long enough to log out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Check and Equip Inventory Items complete.
Tutorial—Stage 2 complete. Rewards will be distributed.
Chain Quest Tutorial—Stage 3 created.

A new reward!

I immediately opened the Inventory to check the new item.

SYSTEM

Inventory
Sharp Spear
Grade: Second Rate
Restriction: None
Effect: 5% chance to inflict Bleeding on hit
Description: A decent enough spear. It's sharp, so be careful when handling it.

"..."

If my Status Window and Skill Window were going to be such a mess, couldn't they at least give me a good item? Then again, considering everything that had happened so far, this was practically generous.

Equip item.

The moment the spear shaft appeared in my grasp—

Ding.

SYSTEM

Tutorial—Stage 3 begins. Prepare yourself.

"…Huh?"

Prepare myself? For what?

I hadn't even opened the quest window yet.

The answer came from an unexpected place.

The taciturn coachman spoke for the first time.

"Young Master."

"Yes?"

"We have a minor problem."

"What are you talking about all of a sudden—"

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Tutorial—Stage 3
You have learned how to grow stronger through the System.
Learning must produce results.
Defeat the bandits who have appeared without warning!
Grade: Tutorial (Chain Quest)
Restriction: First-time player
Objective: Defeat the bandits (Incomplete)
Reward: Recover from all injuries
Chain Quest
Failure: Death

Some minor problem. My ass.

Chapter 4

Jang Sam was a bandit.

Born and raised near Mount Wutai, he had never ventured beyond the surrounding area in his life. Since around the age of twenty, he had made a living extorting tolls from travelers who looked like easy marks.

Perhaps thanks to his diligent round-the-clock operation, the name Heavenly Axe Jang Sam had eventually become fairly well known.

Today was no different. He had risen before dawn and set out to work with his five loyal underlings, the Five-Colored Ghosts… but for some reason, he couldn't stop walking.

How long had he been walking since leaving his home turf of Mount Wutai far behind? When his feet finally came to a halt, he saw a carriage approaching in the distance.

How did I get all the way here?

Had he been bewitched by a ghost? Jang Sam was bewildered, but the moment he saw the luxurious four-horse carriage, his professional instincts came roaring back to life.

I have to take that.

When Jang Sam and the Five-Colored Ghosts blocked the road, the coachman pulled on the reins.

Four fine steeds, their coats gleaming, snorted clouds of vapor as they came to a halt. At a glance, each one looked worth at least a thousand nyang.[22]

Today's my lucky day.

Jang Sam smiled contentedly and adjusted his grip on his axe. Now, put some power into the dantian. One, two—

"Hand over your money!"

What was that voice? Is he an opera singer?

But it would take more than that to make me blink. I'd spent seven years as a Hunter and been through every kind of battle imaginable—even aerial combat.

…Still, he was kind of scary.

"There are six of them in total. I don't see any signs of an ambush."

The coachman reported the situation in a voice as calm as a secret agent's.

Does this guy have some kind of ace up his sleeve? Why is he so relaxed?

When I stared at him, he scratched his head.

[22] Nyang is a traditional unit of money, often reckoned in silver; it is not modern Korean won.

“It happens from time to time. Though this is a first in this area.”

“Why?”

“Why? Unless they belong to a sizable mountain stronghold, attacking a Murim family is practically suicide. Robbing people in the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s own backyard… I wonder what kind of reckless fools they are.”

Who else? Tutorial NPCs.

Judging by the way he kept calling it the Jin Family’s backyard, we must have been fairly close.

Should I stall for time?

My current realm was second-rate.

The way my body felt after distributing my stats was beyond anything I’d experienced as an F-rank Hunter, but I had no idea whether that would be enough in Murim.

Six against one. Six against two, if I counted the coachman.

Could I do it?

There was a reason people said no one could stand against overwhelming numbers. The moment they tied up my hands and feet, I was done for.

“How much farther is it to our destination?”

“We’re nearly there. Another hour should be enough.”

Another hour…?

I’d suspected it, but apparently, the coachman and I had very different definitions of *nearby*.

What do you mean, nearly there?

Maybe it was because this was a continent-sized setting. The scale was different. The scale.

Either way, I had to assume no reinforcements were coming. At least I wasn’t alone.

The coachman’s unflappable attitude practically screamed that he was a master. Just like now.

“Shall I handle this?”

He coiled the horsewhip in his hand as if one crack would separate the bandits’ flesh from their bones.

He’s a master!

Of course. I was the heir of a prestigious martial family and a VIP customer of Honghwaru.[23] There was no way they would have sent an ordinary coachman with me.

Wolhwa must have arranged this. She isn’t just beautiful—she’s kind, too.

[23] Honghwaru is a pleasure house in Taiyuan.

My anxiety vanished, replaced by a pleased smile. The coachman must have taken it as permission, because the moment he turned away, a second shout rang out.

"You bastards! Can't you hear what the Heavenly Axe is saying?"

I peered through the carriage window and saw a hairy man shouting with an enormous double-bladed axe in his hands. His upper body was massive, and his arms and legs were as thick as pillars.

But the coachman muttered as if the sight were laughable.

"Where do these little pups get off?"

Damn, that aura.

Then the coachman laid into them.

"How dare bandits who suck the lifeblood of innocent civilians block our path! I will have you dragged before the authorities and punished to the fullest extent of the law!"

It was a speech worthy of Judge Bao,[24] but the hairy man—the Heavenly Axe—and his underlings didn't seem particularly moved.

"Yeah, we blocked the road. What are you going to do about it?"

"For all the countless crimes you've committed, I will gouge out your eyes, grind your limbs to powder in a mortar, and scatter the dust across the Nine Provinces![25] I will also exterminate all nine degrees of your kin—"

…Those punishments are no joke. That's practically treason.

As if he had read my thoughts, the Heavenly Axe spoke up.

"Hey, is there some member of the imperial family riding inside? Listening to you has my knees shaking. Why don't you let us see that precious face?"

"You will regret not retreating now once you learn this man's identity!"

"Okay, okay. We get it. Now come out already."

"You fools…!"

The coachman clicked his tongue and turned toward me. My heart began to race. Was I finally about to see a true Murim master in action?

"Young Master, I believe you'll have to come out."

"Huh?"

Me? Why me?

"They're the kind who won't cry until they see the coffin. To think they would dare block your path! They'll pay dearly for failing to recognize a master."

With a determined look, he opened the carriage door for me.

---

[24] Judge Bao is the popular name of Bao Zheng, a Song-dynasty official celebrated in Chinese stories for his incorruptible judgments.

[25] The Nine Provinces is a traditional expression for the lands of China.

“I have heard much of the Heaven Shaking Sword’s fame. A genius swordsman who reached the Peak realm at barely twenty! You cannot imagine how my old heart trembled whenever I heard stories about you, Young Master.”

…The Heaven Shaking Sword? A genius swordsman?

My thoughts tangled together. Who was the Heaven Shaking Sword? Who was this genius swordsman who had reached the Peak realm? And what the hell was this coachman playing at?

You said you’d handle it. Weren’t you a master?

“You bastards! Do you know who this man is?”

This was bad. The coachman was barreling ahead like an eight-ton truck with a broken steering wheel.

No. Stop. Please stop!

I grabbed his wrist tightly, and he turned to look at me.

He smiled as if he understood everything. His eyes shone with boundless trust.

“W-wait. I’m Jin—”

Before I could say another word, his thunderous voice rang out.

“He is the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, the Peak master whose name resounds throughout Shanxi! The Heaven Shaking Sword, Young Master Jin Mukyung!”

“I’m Jin… Taekyung.”

At that moment, a cold wind blew.

“Pardon?”

“I mean, I’m Jin Taekyung, not Jin Mukyung. And I’m the Third Young Master, not the Second…”

“…The Third Young Master? *That* Third Young Master?”

Yes, you idiot.

The coachman’s pupils began to tremble. It was an 8.0-magnitude earthquake.

“Th-then where is Young Master Jin Mukyung?”

“How should I know?”

He’s probably sleeping at this hour.

The coachman stared at me with the expression of a man who had lost his country, then collapsed like a deflated inflatable toy.

He had fainted.

Fuck. Some master.

I released his wrist.

His wrist was as thin as a chicken bone. Something had felt off from the moment I grabbed it. He had put on quite a show, only to turn out to be an ordinary civilian.

“Ha! Ha-ha-ha!”

The bandits roared with laughter. My back was already damp with cold sweat, and I hadn't even noticed when it started.

If I'm really unlucky here…

I couldn't bring myself to say the word *death*. I swallowed it instead.

I swept my tense gaze over the bandits.

Fuck. I'd rather fight six goblins than deal with this. How am I supposed to beat guys that huge…?

Wait.

"Huh?"

Was it my imagination? No. No matter how I looked at them, it wasn't.

Massive upper bodies. Thick arms and legs. And… short.

The other five weren't much different. The Heavenly Axe at least had a decent physique, but the rest were about five hundred light-years away from anything you could call "well-built."

In other words, the bandits were built exactly like…

"They're goblins?"

Goblins?

I stood there dazed for a moment until an axe came flying at me and snapped me back to reality. They had the numbers, and they were launching a preemptive attack too?

"Hey, hey! Time out!"

The axe struck the ground a good ten meters[26] short of me. No—it didn't even stick. It toppled over. The bandit who had thrown it scratched the back of his head sheepishly.

"Should I have thrown it a little higher?"

…Maybe.

I might actually survive this.

The monster I had fought more than any other over the past seven years was the goblin.

Naturally, I knew them inside and out. They were even the reason I had chosen a spear as my primary weapon when I was a novice Hunter. Its reach gave me an overwhelming advantage.

And these bandits were exactly that size. To me, they no longer looked like bandits. They looked like six goblins. The Heavenly Axe was about the size of a goblin chieftain.

The other five might be even weaker than goblins.

At least goblins were good with poison darts. Judging by that axe throw, I had a hunch. A very strong hunch.

[26]Ten meters is about 33 ft.

I licked my parched lips, then raised both hands high.

A few of them looked confused by my gesture of surrender, while the Heavenly Axe smiled proudly, like a father watching his son return from military service.

“Good lad.”

Yeah. Laugh while you can.

One step, two. I slowly closed the thirty-meter[27] distance between us.

With a steady stride and balanced posture. One breath per step. My breath escaped my mouth in white clouds that pierced the dawn air.

I could feel it just from putting one foot in front of the other.

It’s different!

I realized it once more.

The version of me inside this game was stronger than the real me.

My heart pounded. At the same time, caution stirred in the back of my mind.

I had to stay focused until the very last moment.

“I heard the Jin Family had a son they’d given up on. Third-rate at martial arts, first-rate with women. Now that I see you, you’ve got pretty good instincts too.”

The Heavenly Axe spoke with the hand holding his axe hanging loosely at his side.

I knew exactly how I looked to them.

A useless playboy with nothing but a good family name. Empty hands.

The Heavenly Axe had let his guard down.

And letting your guard down gets you killed.

I might send most of my salary to my family and live miserably in a tiny goshiwon[28] room, but I was still a Hunter.

Even an F-rank Hunter risked his life fighting inside Gates. No—an F-rank Hunter had to risk his life precisely because he was only F-rank.

For seven years, I had fought every single day. I was a gambler with my life on the line—and a martial artist called a Hunter.

So I knew.

Life and death were separated by a hair’s breadth. Letting your guard down meant death.

The distance had been cut in half. My steps gradually quickened.

The Heavenly Axe beckoned me over.

“Now, now. Take your time. If you trip on the way over, you’ll lower your ransom.”

Twenty meters.[29]

“Boss, doesn’t the way he’s toddling over look just like a puppy?”

---

[27] Thirty meters is about 98 ft.

[28] A goshiwon is a Korean building that rents out small, inexpensive single rooms.

[29] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

Fifteen meters.[30]

“A puppy? Ha-ha-ha! You’ve got that exactly right!”

Ten meters.[31]

The moment I took my next step, heat began to churn in my stomach.

It was a sensation I had never experienced before, yet somehow, it felt strangely familiar. What was it?

Could it be… internal energy?

The heat flowing from my dantian raced toward my lower body.

It had only one purpose: faster, lighter, stronger!

Whoosh. I drew a long breath. My whole body tensed, every muscle drawn tight like a bowstring.

Then came the final step.

Boom!

I shot straight forward. The ground cratered beneath my foot, and the sound followed after me. In that frozen moment, the Heavenly Axe’s mouth slowly fell open.

“No way…”

The Heavenly Axe and his underlings stared at me in disbelief.

I could see everything about them now. Feel it.

Their stiff, greasy hair. Their cracked lips, like a rice paddy in a drought. Their teeth—so foul-looking I could almost smell them…

All of it.

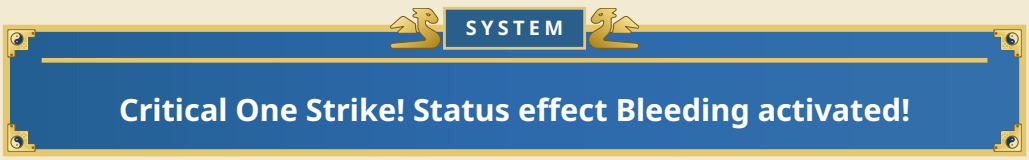
The corners of my mouth lifted before I knew it.

Open Inventory. Equip Sharp Spear.

A cold spear shaft appeared in the hand I had thrust into empty air.

I drove it forward with all my strength. The Heavenly Axe hastily raised his axe to block, but the sharp spearhead shattered the axe blade and punched straight through his chest.

At the same time—



“Ghk!”

A fountain of blood erupted. The Heavenly Axe’s eyes trembled once, then went dark.

[30] Fifteen meters is about 49 ft.

[31] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

SYSTEM

Lv. 10 Jang Sam defeated.
Level up!
You received 10 Stat Points as a level-up reward.
You received 10 Skill Points as a level-up reward.
Jin Family's Cultivation Technique unlocked.

Whew.

I let out a long breath. Notifications had sounded, but all I could hear was my own pounding heart.

One breath. Everything had happened in a single breath. I pulled the spear from the Heavenly Axe's lifeless chest.

So this is possible.

Raise my abilities with points, enhance them with internal energy, and link them together with skills. This was the power of the System—the power that belonged to me alone.

A power F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung could never have dreamed of.

I can do this. I will.

The road home was beginning to look brighter and wider.

I gripped the spear shaft and turned around.

"So…"

The five pairs of eyes fixed on me wavered uncertainly.

"Anyone else want to try?"

The bastard who threw that axe can go first.

"…"

Thud. Thud. Clatter.

The five bandits exchanged glances, dropped their weapons, and threw themselves flat on the ground.

"Please forgive us, Great Hero!"

SYSTEM

The enemies have lost their will to fight and surrendered after losing their leader.
Defeat the Bandits complete.
You have fully recovered from all fatigue and injuries.
You have defeated the bandits. Fame increased by 10.
Tutorial—Stage 3 complete. Rewards will be distributed.
Chain Quest Tutorial—Stage 4 created.

Now I can finally catch my breath.

Chapter 5

“On one, be good. On two, stay alive. Ready? One.”

“Be good!”

“Two.”

“Stay alive!”

“Louder.”

“Be gooood!”

Is this hell?

That was the coachman’s first thought when he came to. His body felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton, and his head was spinning. All the while, scream-like cries continued in the distance.

“Stay aliiive!”

“Louder!”

…This has to be hell.

Every time the grim reaper’s merciless voice rang out, the screams of the dead followed.

“Be gooood!”

Eyes closed, he wept bitter tears of regret. To think he had ended up in hell. If he’d known he would meet such an untimely death, he would at least have made more donations to a temple.

Oh, Mother!

The coachman began to sob, too consumed by grief to notice someone quietly looking down at him.

“Excuse me.”

The coachman’s heart stopped for a split second, then started pounding again. Clutching his chest, he shrieked.

“You nearly scared me to death!”

“…”

“…?”

Now that he’d said it, something seemed off. The coachman stared blankly down at his chest and placed a hand over it.

It was beating. His heart was beating.

And that wasn’t all. The horses were there. So was the carriage. The cold early-winter wind made him shiver.

“I’m alive?”

Hardly daring to believe it, he turned around and saw a man with one eye bruised deep purple. The man's expression was rather strange, but there was no doubt about it.

He was alive.

I'm alive!

"I survived! I'm alive!"

The man pushed the coachman away from his exuberant embrace and answered awkwardly.

"Congratulations."

"Sniff. Sob. Thank you. Thank you so much. But who are you…?"

"Ah, well. We met briefly earlier."

Earlier? Who did I meet earlier?

The coachman knew everyone at Honghwaru by sight, and the day's first guest had been the wastrel of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Where had he seen this traveler he was so grateful to before?

The coachman stared intently at his face, then suddenly sucked in a breath.

"That bandit from earlier!"

"Yes. That was me—"

"The one standing next to the big guy! One of those five idiots who looked like morons!"

"…That's right."

"The shortest one!"

"…"

"The ugliest one!"

"…"

"And the one with the smallest package!"

"No, I'm not!"

The bandit's shout brought the coachman to his senses.

What did I just say?

Regret and despair surged over him like a rising tide.

Now I'm really dead.

He almost wished he were already dead. At least then there wouldn't be any pain.

But then—

"Whew. Enough nonsense. Just follow me."

The bandit, who looked like a ferocious demon, calmed down in an instant and started walking ahead. The coachman found himself following and was struck by a strange sense of déjà vu.

This feels like I'm being escorted.

Compared to before the coachman had passed out, the bandit's manner wasn't merely subdued—it was downright polite. Mustering every ounce of courage he had, the coachman spoke.

"Um, where are we going?"

"To the boss."

The coachman's face went white. He remembered what he had said to the Heavenly Axe.

Gouge out his eyes, grind his limbs to powder in a mortar...

I need to run. Right now.

But the next moment, his legs began to tremble, and cold sweat poured off him like rain. He couldn't take a single step.

Dark red blood was splattered everywhere. A leg that seemed to belong to a corpse jutted from the bushes beside the road.

These lunatics.

He had feared as much, but they had actually killed someone in broad daylight—and not just anyone, but a young master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

The coachman knew he was going to die.

Until someone emerged from the bushes.

"Oh, you're awake?"

Behind him, the bandits were panting with their arms slung over one another's shoulders.

Each of them sported a matching bruise around one eye.

"What are you doing, punk? Can't you see your comrades busting their asses? Get over here and help."

"Yes, Boss."

"You little bastard. How many times have I told you not to call me that?"

The coachman watched the scene in a daze and thought:

At least I'm still alive.

"So that's what happened."

The coachman's eyes lit up like flashlights as he listened to the story.

Ow, my eyes. He's blinding me. I can barely look at him.

"Um, excuse me."

What now?

"Are you really Young Master Jin Mukyung?"

"...Please, just stop."

How many times do I have to tell him? I'm Jin Taekyung.

He was an NPC who drove me insane in every possible way. I couldn't decide whether to call it a triumph of artificial intelligence or a failure.

If I knew how to drive a carriage, I would've ditched him ages ago.

"Are you finished?"

The coachman answered as he tied the final knot.

"Yes. It's all done."

What knot, you ask? The knots in the ropes binding the five bandits hand and foot. He had tied them so tightly that their pitiful groans never stopped.

"Boss. Could you loosen them just a little?"

"Nope. Can't do that. Won't do it. Stay put."

"Please, Boss. Give your little brothers the chance to serve you—"

"Call me Boss one more time, and I'll give you the chance to serve Yama.[32]"

Leaving their silence behind, I climbed into the carriage.

I had already confiscated the bandits' weapons and placed them in my Inventory, and the level-up effect had restored me to perfect condition.

"We're leaving."

The coachman took up the reins, and the four-horse carriage began to move.

The mountain road was as well maintained as the hiking trails behind town. Cool wind and mountain air flowed in through the carriage window.

It's incredible, no matter how I look at it.

I shook my head.

Science. Technology. Whatever you called it, it was beyond my comprehension.

Besides, in my current situation, even thinking about that was a luxury.

Damn it. What the hell is the time ratio in this game?

Virtual-reality games had something called a time ratio. If the ratio between reality and virtual reality was one to three, three hours in virtual reality would mean only one hour had passed in the real world.

That was why I had forced myself to hold out at Honghwaru for three days.

I had been clinging to the hope that someone would get me out by then.

What the hell is Seong Jinho doing?

A deep sigh escaped me. At the same time, a sliver of unease began to creep in.

What if the time ratio is wildly different?

No way.

It couldn't be. Jinho hyung[33] had once told me that a capsule's time ratio was proportional to its performance and price. A piece of junk like this couldn't possibly manage an extreme ratio.

---

[32] Yama is the lord of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

[33] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

Though it was performing better than I'd expected.

No. It's performing unbelievably well.

I hadn't played a game in years, but I wasn't so clueless that I couldn't recognize that much. *Murim* was clearly a high-spec game, yet this old capsule was running it without any trouble.

That alone was astonishing. So—

Please stop giving me new things to be astonished by.

Please. I muttered the word like a spell and opened my Skill Window.

SYSTEM

Skill Window
LV. 11 Jin Taekyung
Cultivation Technique: Jin Family's Cultivation Technique
Martial Arts: Jin Family's Spear Technique / Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique (Unavailable)
Muscles and Bones: 70
Sinews and Meridians: 50
Remaining Points: 10
Distribute your remaining points.
You have forgotten the formulas because you have not trained in martial arts for a long time.
You can view information about your acquired skills.

It was astonishing even the second time I saw it. I couldn't use my martial arts because I hadn't trained?

How much had this guy slacked off?

With a sigh, I moved on. First were the remaining points.

Apparently, I received ten points every time I gained a Level. The Status Window probably worked the same way.

If I combine the Skill Window and Status Window, does that mean I get twenty points every time I level up?

That felt like a strangely awkward amount. I put off distributing my points and touched the final sentence.

SYSTEM

Would you like to view your acquired skills?

View all.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Skill Window
Jin Family's Spear Technique
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: Must have learned Jin Family's Cultivation Technique
Realm: Unknown
Effect: Unknown
Description: A hereditary martial art of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Can be learned through a martial arts manual. Currently unavailable because you have forgotten the formula.
Skill Window
Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: Must have learned Jin Family's Cultivation Technique
Realm: Unknown
Effect: Unknown
Description: A hereditary martial art of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Can be learned through a martial arts manual. Currently unavailable because you have forgotten the formula.
Skill Window
Jin Family's Cultivation Technique
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan
Realm: Second Stage
Effect: Allows you to circulate and accumulate internal energy through qi circulation.
Description: Exceptionally stable, but slow to accumulate internal energy.

Hmm.

The first thing that caught my eye was the grade.

The Spear Technique and Manoeuvre Technique were First Rate. Only the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was Peak. It was also the only one with a clearly listed realm and effect.

I haven't even been able to try the Spear Technique or Manoeuvre Technique. As for the Cultivation Technique…not bad.

Who cared how slowly it accumulated internal energy? Exceptionally stable. That was all I needed. My motto in life was to keep my head down and live a long time.

That was when—

SYSTEM

Quest
Tutorial—Stage 4
You can now use Circulate Qi to control internal energy.
However, uncontrolled internal energy is a double-edged sword.
Do not let your guard down until the very end!
Grade: Tutorial (Final)
Restriction: First-time player
Objective: Circulate Qi (Incomplete)
Reward: Item Chest
Qi Sense acquired
Main Quest unlocked
Failure: Status Effect Qi Deviation or Death
Would you like to accept the Quest?
Accept / Decline

I answered without hesitation.

Nope. Not doing it.

A reward? I didn't need some lousy reward. There had to be a limit to this bullshit. Were these lunatics really trying to bargain with me by putting game items on one side and my life on the other?

SYSTEM

Your response is being delayed.

Look at it trying to pull a cheap trick.

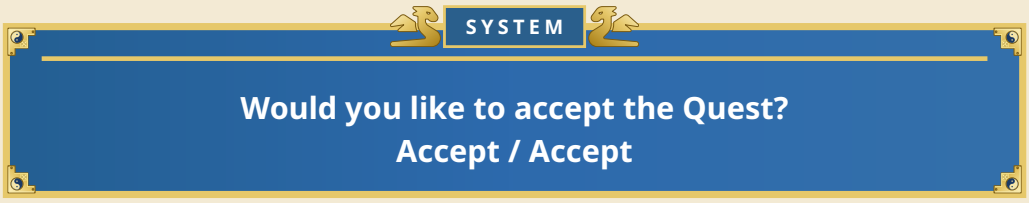
Ignoring the coachman's stare, I enunciated each syllable.

"De-cline."

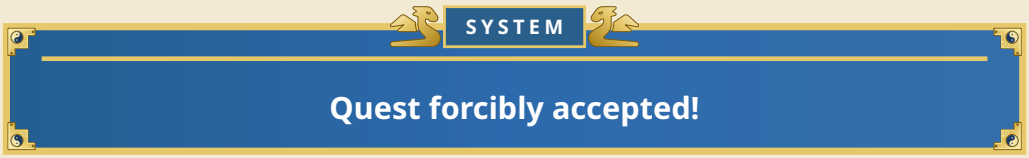
SYSTEM

Tutorial Quests cannot be declined.

"…?"

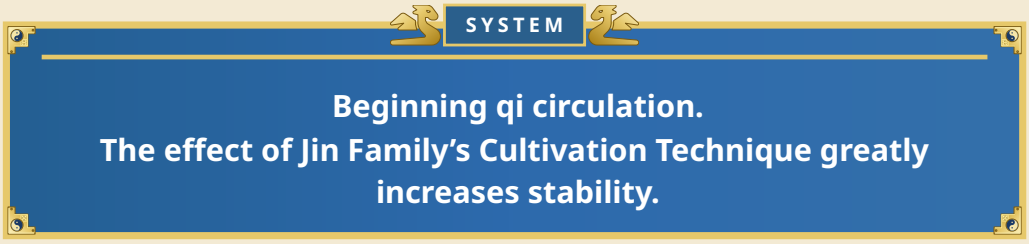


“I said decline! Why are both options Accept?”



“Hey! You sons of bitches!”

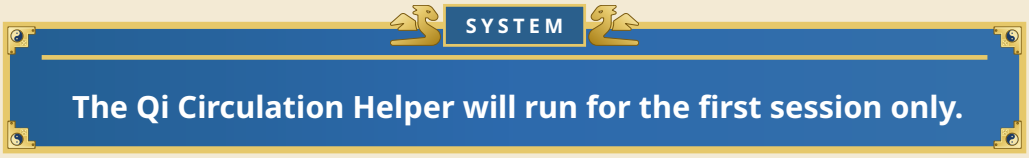
The string of curses I had been holding back finally burst out.



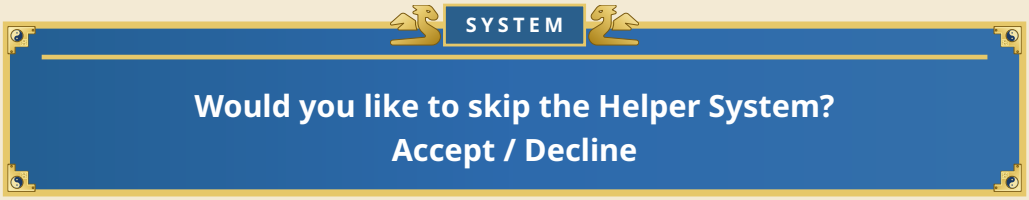
I had never missed my family as much as I did then. My beloved mother. My adorable little sister…or rather, my pain-in-the-ass little sister, Hayeon.

When I get out, your big brother will buy you enough fried chicken to make your stomach burst.

If I ever get out.



This was like stabbing someone and then applying ointment to the wound…



I fixed my trembling gaze on the message window.

“D-Decline.”

SYSTEM

Continuing.

That was a coincidence, right? Yeah. It had to be.

Before my unease had even faded, my vision flipped upside down.

When I came to, I was in an unfamiliar gray space.

“Over here.”

I whipped my head around in surprise and saw an old man beckoning me.

If an old man who looked like that called me over in a dream, I’d turn around and run for my life. But this was a game.

So he’s the helper.

Even if I hadn’t reasoned it out, I would have followed him without much suspicion.

It was strange, even to me, but that was how I felt. An inexplicable sense of familiarity. And trust.

“Take whatever position you find most comfortable.”

Huh? Aren’t you supposed to sit cross-legged when circulating qi?

As if he had read my thoughts, the old man answered.

“Weaklings are the ones who fuss over things like that. Masters don’t need to.”

I could smell it in his calm voice. I could smell it.

This was the scent of a master. The real deal had finally appeared!

“Good grief. What a handful.”

His wrinkled hand seemed to reach toward me, then vanished in a blur.

Huh?

Tap. Tap-tap.

Something flashed past, and the next moment, I was frozen stiff.

Was this what it felt like to be a corpse with its eyes still open?

I couldn’t move a muscle.

“It’s only a simple Pressure-Point Strike, so don’t be alarmed. Focus from this point on.”

As he spoke, the old man placed a hand on my back. Then he rapidly rattled off words in a low voice.

“Circulating qi is the most important form of training for a martial artist. It not only allows you to accumulate internal energy, but also refines essence, qi, and spirit, enabling you to advance to a higher realm. Therefore…”

I listened closely, but I couldn’t understand a word of what came after that. All I gathered was that circulating qi was extremely important.

“Clear your mind like a stream, maintain your focus, and draw out the flow. Now I will recite the formula of the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.”

Without giving me time to stop him, he rattled off the formula at breakneck speed, like beans popping in a pan—but I could understand it all. It felt as though a foreign language were being translated automatically inside my head.

What is this?

The formula was exactly 318 characters long. The moment I felt it become perfectly engraved in my mind, something changed.

“Descend.”

One word from the old man.

Where to?

Before the question could fade, I felt myself being drawn somewhere deep.

No—it only felt as though I was being drawn in.

My eyes were definitely closed, but I could see. I could feel.

The breeze that gently blew in before scattering. Sunlight. The coachman’s breathing and the horses’ snorts…

I pushed all of it away.

There was only one place to focus on: my body.

SYSTEM

Beginning the circulation of Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique. Follow the glowing acupoints.

I didn’t notice the old man disappear. I didn’t even hear the System’s voice.

My consciousness stirred awake in my head and slid downward. I didn’t know the points shining like stars were acupoints. Everything simply felt familiar, as though it had always been this way.

At last, I reached my dantian.

A small but pure energy.

Ten years of internal energy.

But what’s that?

In one corner of my dantian was something else, as large and hard as a boulder.

I understood instinctively.

Another store of internal energy.

It was energy that I—Jin Taekyung—had not yet assimilated and made my own. There was nearly as much of it as the internal energy I already possessed.

What if I absorb it?

There was no question that I would become stronger.

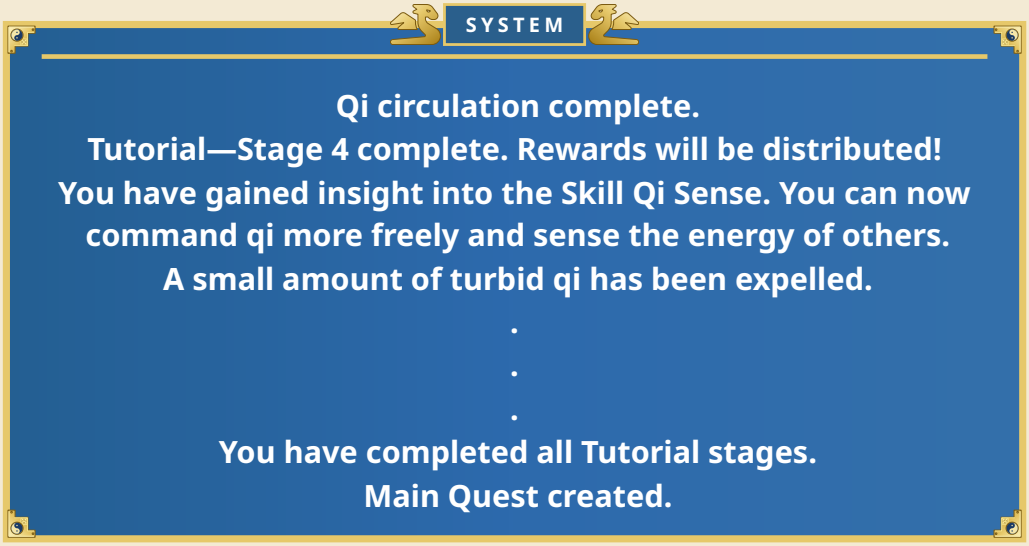
But for me, right now, it would be a reckless challenge. An adventure without a purpose.

I can't push my luck and die out here.

I steadied my mind and stirred my internal energy. Following the path the System's voice had shown me, I slowly guided it along.

At some point, I thought I faintly heard someone's voice.

"Good judgment."



As the System's final announcement sounded, the coachman spoke.

"We've arrived. This is the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Yeah. At last.

Chapter 6

From the hill above, the Jin Family of Taiyuan looked like a village unto itself.

Dozens of buildings, large and small, spread across the vast grounds, while high stone walls enclosed the entire estate without leaving a single gap.

And that wasn't all. The cliff looming behind the Jin Family of Taiyuan was a spectacle in its own right.

Nature that had weathered the ages, and one family crouched beneath it.

The sight alone was imposing.

"Wow."

Even the coachman was impressed. Wait a minute.

"Didn't you say you'd been here often?"

"This is my second time."

"…How long have you been working?"

"Not even a month."

This guy had more layers than an onion.

He looked and carried himself like a twenty-year veteran, yet he was a new hire.

Then again, if he really had that much experience, there was no way he wouldn't recognize this face.

I'd practically worn down Honghwaru's threshold with all my visits. If he was new, it made sense that he might mistake me for Jin Mukyung.

Good thing everything worked out.

I had completed the final Tutorial Quest, and the Jin Family of Taiyuan was right in front of me. I could finally relax a little.

"Could you slow down a bit?"

"Ah, yes."

As the carriage slowed, I opened my Skill Window.

SYSTEM

Skill Window
Qi Sense
Grade: None
Restriction: None
Realm: 1st Mastery
Effect: Can identify targets at or below Lv. 30.
Description: Scans targets within a designated range. As the realm rises, the scan range and maximum target level increase.

When I finished reading the description, something occurred to me.

That's exactly what it is. A power-level scanner.

In a famous manga, they used a mechanical device to measure an opponent's power level.[34] I wondered how Qi Sense would work.

Curious, I called the command to mind.

Activate Qi Sense.

Was that right? The instant I hesitated, a blue circle appeared beneath my feet and a notification chimed.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You used Qi Sense. Since your current realm is 1st Mastery, you can scan targets at or below Lv. 30 within 10 jang.[35]

Ten jang—that was thirty meters.[36]

Whoosh.

Blue concentric rings swept outward, catching someone within their radius. A System window popped up over the coachman's round head.

SYSTEM

You identified the target with Qi Sense.
Lv. 4 Jang Sam

Aha. So that was how it worked.

Easy, simple, and most of all…

It was an essential skill for survival. Whether an enemy was strong, weak, or roughly on my level—I could find out at once by using Qi Sense.

I picked up a good one.

I nodded and opened the Quest Window. The moment I checked the new Main Quest, my mouth fell open before I knew it.

"…Huh?"

The world seemed to brighten before my eyes. If Qi Sense was a single ray of light reflected in a sewer, this was the sun. My heart pounded, and my head grew hot.

[34] The device alludes to the scouter in *Dragon Ball*, which displays a fighter's power level.
[35] A jang is about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30 m (99 ft).
[36] A jang is about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30 m (99 ft).

SYSTEM

Quest
Logout
Now you must make your way through this harsh Murim.
Grow stronger and become famous.
For that day, when it finally comes...
Grade: Main Quest
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Objective: Reach the First Rate realm (Incomplete)
Reach Lv. 30 (Incomplete)
Reach 500 Fame (Incomplete)
Reward: Logout

The word I had been desperate to see.

Logout!

I was overjoyed, but dazed too. I had been determined to survive by any means necessary, yet a sliver of anxiety had always lingered in the back of my mind. *Can I get out? What if I'm trapped here forever?* Those dark suspicions had never quite left me.

I can get out.

But now things were different. I finally knew I could log out. It felt as though my mind had awakened anew.

Yeah, fuck it. It's only a game.

A Quest? How hard could it be?

For seven years, I had crossed the line between life and death almost every day. A Hunter's ability to survive—and sheer willpower—were beyond comparison with an ordinary person's.

And then there's this power.

My fist clenched on its own. All of this might be virtual, but the strength surging through my body felt real.

That was how I knew.

I was stronger in the game than I was in reality.

Only by the slightest margin, but there was no doubt about it.

It's all thanks to the System.

Leveling up, Quests, distributing stats, and Skills. All of it came from the System. It was only possible because this was a game and I was a player.

With my experience as a Hunter and the System at my disposal, logging out was only a matter of time.

Once I get out, they're all fucking dead.

I'd start by beating the shit out of the game's developers. Fucking bastards. I was grinding my teeth when someone shouted in my ear.

"Stop!"

Matching uniforms. Disciplined postures. Clipped voices.

The moment I saw the martial artists guarding the Jin Family of Taiyuan's main gate, the word *Murim* flashed through my mind.

So this is what a prestigious family is like.

They were clearly different. If the Heavenly Axe and the bandits I'd encountered earlier were a rabble, these men were trained regulars.

One of the NPCs approached the coachman. He was a young martial artist with a boyish face and thick caterpillar eyebrows.

"I am Hyuk Mujin, Captain of the Gatekeepers of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan. State your identity and purpose."

Captain of the Gatekeepers. Come to think of it, he was the only one wearing a sash that resembled an armband. He barely looked twenty.

Then again, if you're talented enough, that's all that matters.

While I was thinking that, the coachman answered.

"We're from Honghwaru."

"Honghwaru? You mean the pleasure house?"

"Yes."

Through the window, I saw the NPC's face—or rather, Hyuk Mujin's—twist into a frown. His previously courteous tone turned curt at once.

"What business could a pleasure house possibly have with our family?"

"Ah, well…"

No matter where you went, there were always people like that—the kind who worked for a conglomerate and thought that made them a chaebol,[37] when the actual chaebol was someone else entirely.

I quietly opened the window and coughed.

"Ahem. Hmm-hmm."

A very deliberate cough. The famous *Don't you know who I am?* cough, reserved for those who had made it in life.

"Hmm."

Sure enough, Hyuk Mujin recognized me at a glance. I gave him a mild smile and spoke.

[37] A chaebol is a large, family-controlled South Korean business conglomerate; the word can also refer to its wealthy owners.

It was a magic phrase used far and wide by high-ranking politicians, military officers, and businessmen.

“Hmm. Right. Good work.”

I was about to close the window when—

Clack. Rattle.

“Huh?”

It wouldn’t close. A hand had shot forward and caught it.

The hand belonged, of course, to Hyuk Mujin. Through the half-closed window, I saw his stiff expression.

“Get down.”

“Me?”

“Who else? Did you think I was talking to the air?”

What the hell? Why was this guy reacting like that?

He didn’t recognize me after all.

I put on a generous smile.

“You might not know this, but I live here.”

“So do I.”

“No, what I mean is…”

“You’re the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Is that what you’re trying to say?”

“…”

Exactly right. Hyuk Mujin continued.

“I know perfectly well who you are, Young Master. Now get down from the carriage. We’ll proceed according to protocol.”

What else could I do? He said it was protocol. But warning lights were flashing in my head as I climbed down from the carriage.

Why do I have such a bad feeling about this?

The other NPCs in the Jin Family of Taiyuan were giving me strangely chilly looks too. Just as their stares began to make my face burn, Hyuk Mujin took out paper and a brush and spoke.

“Name.”

“…”

“I’ll ask again. Name.”

What was this, a criminal interrogation?

I was in a foul mood, but I decided to wait and see what happened.

“…Jin Taekyung.”

“Affiliation.”

“Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Age and martial arts realm.”

“Twenty. Second Rate.”

Hyuk Mujin’s brush paused.

“Don’t let pointless pride get in the way. Answer honestly.”

Honestly?

Would you understand if I said I reached the Second Rate realm by distributing stats?

When I merely stared at him instead of answering, he shook his head.

“Well, if you insist, we’ll move on. Let’s see… You’ve been away for several days. Where did you go?”

“Honghwaru.”

“Several days at the famously expensive Honghwaru? Must have been nice. You must have spent a fortune. Or did you skim the family funds again?”

“Again?”

“Why pretend otherwise? Isn’t that something the Young Master has done now and then, time and time again, as a matter of course?”

The hostility in Hyuk Mujin’s eyes reminded me of something.

Jin Taekyung.

For a moment, I had forgotten what kind of person the character Jin Taekyung was in this game—especially within the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

The Shame of the Family.

There was no way the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s NPCs would like someone saddled with a title like that. As if to prove it, every ounce of their contempt was now directed at me.

In this game where nothing ever went my way.

Ah, for fuck’s sake…

Something surged up from deep in my chest. My head throbbed, and my eyes grew hot. Then a low voice reached me.

“Third Young Master, I may only be a low-ranking Captain, but let me say one thing.”

His expression said it all.

What a pathetic bastard.

“Stop tarnishing the family’s reputation. At least try to live like a human being. Understood?”

He tossed out the remark and turned away. I stared blankly at the back of his head, then let out a hollow laugh.

“Live like a human being?”

I knew Hyuk Mujin was nothing more than an NPC who knew nothing.

I knew he was saying it to Jin Taekyung, not to me.

But…

This is fucking bullshit.

The fact that this was a game and Hyuk Mujin was an NPC didn't matter. No—I decided not to think about it.

All the stress that had built up erupted, shattering the last of my patience.

"Hey. You. Stop right there."

Hyuk Mujin turned around, irritation written all over his face. I'd been wanting to punch that face for a while now.

I beamed like a child who had just seen Santa Claus.

"You're… fucking dead."

I sent my clenched fist flying toward his jaw.

The air hung heavy. A pile of documents towered over the desk. And, as always, a cold-looking escort stood beside his master like a shadow.

Scratch. Scratch.

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion swallowed. His mouth had been bone-dry from the moment he entered the office.

"Tell me."

The calm voice from beyond the pile of documents was an oasis.

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion finally managed to speak.

"There is a promising young man among my subordinates. He's quite loyal to our family and possesses considerable martial talent, but…"

"I'm listening."

"Perhaps because he's young, he's arrogant and insolent. He never thinks before he acts."

"Get to the point."

"I hear he got into a fight with the Third Young Master."

"…I can imagine. What about the youngest?"

"We moved him to Medicine King Hall immediately. He's unconscious, with some bruising…"

Silence fell.

"It was all my fault. Please punish me severely!"

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion bowed deeply, his vision going dark. A long while passed before the voice came again.

"That's enough. You may leave."

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion raised his head, feeling as though he had narrowly escaped death.

“Ah, one more thing.”

“Your command, Lesser Family Head.”

“Could I see that young man? I’d like to speak with him for a moment.”

“Lesser Family Head, forgive me for saying so, but his treatment isn’t finished yet.”

“Treatment?”

“Yes. He’s at Medicine King Hall too. I hear one of his bones was cracked.”

“…Is that so? Then never mind.”

The silence continued even after the Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion withdrew, until the precarious tower of documents came crashing down.

“Wipeng.”

Jin Wikyung, the thirty-five-year-old Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, called to his trusted retainer with a stiff expression.

“Yes.”

“I’m going to step out for a while.”

Here we go again.

Wipeng, Jin Wikyung’s escort, let out an inscrutable sigh as he watched his master walk away.

Chapter 7

I'm dreaming.

How do I know? Well…

Because I'm watching myself?

I mean that literally. I'm watching myself—or, more precisely, Jin Taekyung in the game, not the real-world me.

"Huff, huff."

Jin Taekyung gasped for breath. His clothes were torn, and his face and body were covered in bruises and swelling.

Meanwhile…

That bastard's perfectly fine.

Hyuk Mujin was still fresh. He even had enough breathing room to sneer at his opponent.

"You're better than I expected, but…you can't fight that crudely. A martial artist ought to use martial arts."

God, what an annoying bastard. I wanted to run over and smack him in the back of the head, but maybe because it was a dream, I couldn't move or make a sound.

Watching it like this just pisses me off even more.

That was right. This dream was showing me my earlier fight with Hyuk Mujin from a third-person perspective.

"You fucking sooon of a bitch!"

Jin Taekyung charged at him with a furious scream, but it was pointless. I knew because I'd been there.

By then, I was already exhausted.

My arms and legs were heavy, and my breathing was ragged. My movements had grown wider, leaving plenty of openings.

Sure enough, Hyuk Mujin easily dodged the punch, then kicked Taekyung's leg out from under him.

His movements were smooth and nimble, flowing like water. The entire fight had been a series of moments like that.

Bastard really can fight.

I had to admit it. Hyuk Mujin was stronger than me. He used his internal energy efficiently and neutralized me every time with martial arts I didn't recognize.

In a word, he was a true martial artist of Murim.

It was a shock.

I'd gotten cocky after taking down the Heavenly Axe. I'd vaguely assumed I was already strong enough to hold my own. Add my seven years of combat experience

as a Hunter and the power of the System, and I'd thought logging out was only a matter of time.

That was exactly the kind of thinking that gets you killed.

The Heavenly Axe and those bandits had been nothing more than tutorial monsters.

I'd been celebrating after killing a Level 1 rabbit in a beginner hunting ground. A seven-year Hunter? My thinking had been so shallow it made a joke of all that experience.

I have to learn martial arts.

This wasn't just a game. My life was on the line.

I had to do whatever it took to survive. Level up, learn martial arts—whatever it took, I was ready to learn and struggle with everything I had.

I was ready to become a martial artist of Murim instead of an F-rank Hunter.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

"Fuck. You're tough as hell. Let go! You won't let go!"

"Graaagh!"

Jin Taekyung kept getting knocked down, only to rise again. No—that was me.

I did land one good hit at the very end.

Smack!

Yeah. That's how you do it. The way I have for the past seven years. The way I always have.

But what Level is Hyuk Mujin?

At that moment, as if answering my question, a System window rose above Hyuk Mujin's head.

...Should I just shut up and level up first?

I opened my eyes to the System's voice. For a split second, I imagined waking up in my room at the goshiwon[38], but it was a pointless hope.

[38] A *goshiwon* is a building of small, low-cost rooms, often rented by students or people living alone in South Korea.

"Are you awake, Young Master?"

I looked around at the man dressed in white. A strange smell hung in the neat, clean room.

Where am I?

As if he had read my mind, the man answered.

"This is Medicine King Hall. You regained consciousness half a shichen[39] after you fainted."

So this was a Korean medicine clinic, and this NPC was a physician.

Half a shichen… Was I unconscious for an hour?

That bastard Hyuk Mujin had really laid into me.

"You'll be in considerable pain from the bruising. Please lie still for a while."

With that, the physician left the room. Once his footsteps had faded, I quietly muttered,

"Open Status Window."

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 11 Jin Taekyung
Occupation: Second Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 10
Titles: Scion of a Prestigious Family / Shame of the Family
(Title effects active)
Strength: 40 **Stamina:** 40
Agility: 50 **Intelligence:** 10
Charm: 10 **Internal Energy:** 10 years
Unassigned Points: 10
Distribute your unassigned points.

The ten points I'd earned from defeating the Heavenly Axe were still there. I'd held off on distributing them in case something unexpected happened, but I hadn't expected to end up fighting Hyuk Mujin.

I hadn't expected to get beaten to a pulp, either.

After thinking for a moment, I put all ten points into Stamina.

The sight of myself exhausted and gasping during the fight with Hyuk Mujin was still fresh in my mind.

If I'd distributed the points beforehand, would I have stood a chance?

The thought crossed my mind, but I soon shook my head.

[39] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

The outcome wouldn't have changed.

It had been a fight between an adult and a child. The gap between Hyuk Mujin and me was that vast.

And as far as I was concerned, that gap had less to do with Levels and stats than with whether or not we knew martial arts.

How could he react like that? Move like that?

Martial arts did exist in the real world too. Boxing, krav maga, jiu-jitsu, and so on—the things people called practical martial arts these days.

But martial arts here were on an entirely different level.

Every movement was both practical and precise, like interlocking gears driven by internal energy.

I have to learn martial arts.

What if I'd encountered Hyuk Mujin in the tutorial instead of the Heavenly Axe?

Defeat. Death. The words came naturally to mind.

I had to learn martial arts. I wouldn't survive without them.

"Fuuuck…"

As I let out a long, vicious curse from the bottom of my lungs, I heard someone outside the door.

"This is the room."

"Thank you."

Creak.

The door opened before I could react. And there, standing in the doorway…

"Well, aren't you a sight."

A middle-aged man was glaring at me with icy eyes.

"What's his condition?"

"He has bruises, but nothing too serious."

"That's a shame. He should have broken a leg, at least."

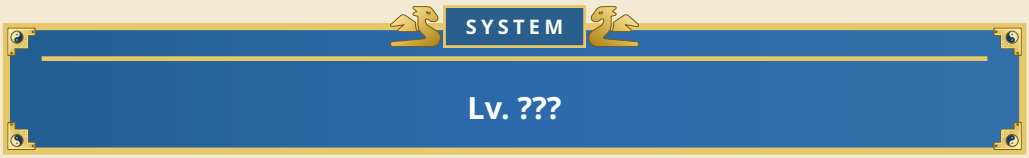
"…"

The middle-aged man fixed me with a menacing glare.

"You reckless little bastard!"

I quietly lowered my eyes. I had never seen this man—or rather, this NPC—before, but for some reason, I felt like I should.

No. I absolutely had to.



Three question marks. Even Qi Sense couldn't identify his Level.

At least Level 30.

He made Hyuk Mujin look cute. More importantly, judging by the physician's attitude and the way this man spoke to me, he was no ordinary NPC.

At the very least, he seemed to have enough authority to slap the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan right across the mouth.

If that hits me…

Gulp.

I swallowed involuntarily at the sight of his palm, which was as large as a pot lid.

Level aside, the man looked dangerous in every way.

He stood nearly two meters[40] tall, his entire body sheathed in muscles like a bulletproof vest. His cold gaze was enough to freeze a person solid.

He looked like murder was both his hobby and his specialty, and I found myself wondering who he was.

But his face looks strangely familiar.

Where had I seen this man before? I thought hard, then realized.

Jin Taekyung?

The middle-aged man looked like Jin Taekyung. No—it would be more accurate to say Jin Taekyung looked like him.

His incomprehensibly high Level. The way he spoke while trampling all over the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. And finally, his face.

There could only be one answer. He was Jin Taekyung's…

"Father?"

The word slipped out before I could stop it, and the middle-aged man's eyes bulged.

"F-Father?"

Even his fist began to tremble. Anyone watching would have thought I'd insulted his mother. Keeping a wary eye on his fist, I said,

"Please, just calm down for a moment…"

"Calm down? You dare say that to me? You're still playing games at a time like this!"

"I'm very sorry if I got it wrong. I spoke out of turn."

"Shut your mouth."

[40] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

He silenced me with a chilly glare, then turned to the physician, who was still waiting nearby.

“Thank you for showing me here. You may leave now.”

I sent the physician a desperate SOS with my eyes, but he immediately turned away.

What the fuck… A doctor is abandoning his patient?

Bang.

The door slamming shut sounded like the gates of hell opening.

Alone together in the room, the man raised his pot-lid-sized palm and began walking toward me.

“There’s a limit to how much of a wastrel you can be! How long are you going to keep living like this?”

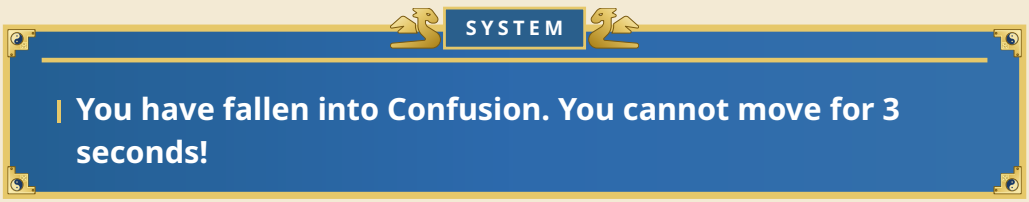
Before I knew it, I had jumped to my feet and was slowly backing away.

Bruises? Pain? I couldn’t feel any of that anymore. Maybe I was about to end up in a body that would never feel pain again.

“Give me just ten minutes. No, a quarter hour. I can explain everything properly. What are you angry about? Huh? Is it because I called you Father? Are you actually my mother?”

“You little brat!”

His booming voice made my body lock up. I felt my back touch the wall.



What the actual fuck…

I’m finished.

My twenty-seven years of life flashed before my eyes. With a little exaggeration, I even remembered the fierce race to reach the egg back when I was still a sperm. That had been rough.

Mom, Dad, Hayeon…

I thought of my family and slowly closed my eyes.

“Whenever you get a chance, all you do is chase women!”

Pat, pat.

“You’re always in and out of gambling dens!”

Fondle, fondle.

“This is why the family looks down on you!”

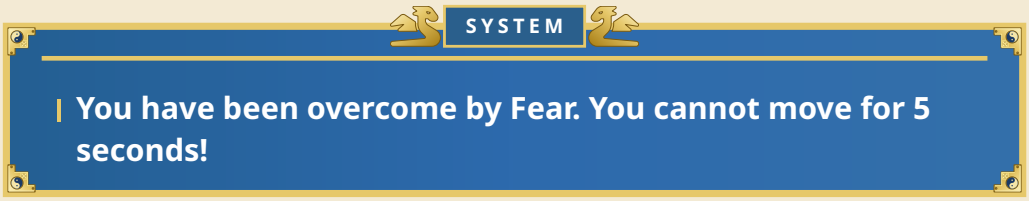
Rub, rub.

…What the hell was this guy doing?

His mouth kept pouring out angry scoldings, but his hands were gently feeling me all over. A chill ran down my spine.

No way…

Ding.



“You’re a disgrace to the family. A disgrace!”

I certainly was feeling overwhelming shame. I was being sexually harassed by an AI—and one that looked like a middle-aged man, at that.

Mom…

It took me a moment to realize that I had completely misunderstood.

His hands moved quickly, but they moved like those of a physician examining a patient.

He lifted my eyelids, checked my pulse, and carefully examined the bruised areas. Every time his hands passed over me, the pain faded and my body felt refreshed, as if I were getting a massage.

“You little bastard! Keep acting like this and—huh? Huh!—you’ll get what’s coming to you. Do you understand?”

“…”

At last, he stopped moving his hands and whispered,

“Thank goodness it’s not as bad as I expected. Why did you have to fight him? You never even train in martial arts.”

I answered with complete sincerity. It was one question loaded with all kinds of meaning.

“Who are you?”

The next moment, his stern, solemn, serious expression transformed into that of a wounded fawn.

“Why are you speaking formally all of a sudden? When I called you a disgrace to the family, I only said it for other people to hear… Did it hurt your feelings?”

“Huh?”

“Your big brother is sad. You know how dearly I raised you. When you were little, I changed your dirty diapers every day, carried you around whenever you cried, and soothed you to sleep.”

“Huh? You’re my brother?”

Silence fell.

He was my brother, not my father?

I was stunned that this old guy was my brother.

“Oh dear, our youngest must have hurt his head. Physician! Physician!”

The middle-aged man ran out shouting for the physician. As I watched him go, a piece of the puzzle suddenly fell into place.

Now I understand why Jin Taekyung grew up such a mess.

A shining example of what happens when parenting goes wrong.

Chapter 8

"There's nothing wrong with him."

That was the physician's conclusion. Hearing the certainty in his voice, I nodded to myself. He was right.

There's nothing wrong with my brain.

I was simply inhabiting this body.

But someone didn't seem satisfied with the diagnosis.

"Then why can't he remember anything?"

A dignified air and a commanding voice. I knew his name now.

Jin Wikyung.

Jin Taekyung's eldest brother and the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Right. He really wasn't my father.

The man was even tearing up earlier.

Now he was pretending nothing had happened, his stern, solemn, serious mask firmly back in place.

The poor physician fumbled for an answer.

"Well, that is certainly my diagnosis, but there can occasionally be exceptions…"

"That will do. You may leave."

The physician left looking wounded. As if he had been waiting for the chance, Jin Wikyung immediately moved closer. His voice overflowed with affection and concern.

"You truly don't remember?"

"No."

"Not a thing?"

I quietly nodded. I had already worked out how I was going to play this.

Let's keep going like this.

Amnesia—the kind I had only ever seen in dramas. Nothing could have been more convenient in my current situation. I didn't have to make any effort to fit into the game world or dig up information.

All I had to do was lie still, blink at everyone with an expression that said *I don't know anything*, and let events unfold on their own. Just like now.

"Do you remember what you just said?"

"Which part?"

Believing that I had lost my memory, Jin Wikyung had told me a few basic facts. That was how I had learned who he was.

"Tell me my name."

"Jin Wikyung. The Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

“How old am I?”

“Thirty-five.”

Good grief. He was in his thirties with that face? He wasn’t even married yet.

“What about our parents?”

“Our father is touring the Central Plains. Our mother died ten years ago.”

“That’s right. And your second brother?”

“Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword. Twenty-five. Currently a cadet at Heaven’s Gate Temple.”

I had no idea where Heaven’s Gate Temple was. I was simply parroting back what I had heard.

Jin Wikyung had been mechanically saying, “That’s right, that’s right,” after each answer, but now he tilted his head.

“The Heaven Shaking Sword? Did I tell you his sobriquet too?”

No. The coachman had told me that.

The moment our eyes met, I clutched my forehead.

“Ah, my head! My head hurts!”

“Oh no, my youngest!”

This was practically a cheat code.

“It’s only a simple contusion. The swelling and bruises should be completely gone within three days at most.”

Leaving the physician’s final words behind, I walked out of Medicine King Hall. A servant with an unassuming, approachable face was waiting for me at the entrance.

“I’ll show you to your quarters, Young Master.”

The servant set off without hesitation. He already seemed to know that I had lost my memory, because whenever we passed a building or a person, he would quietly explain who or what they were.

A guide, an errand boy, and an encyclopedia.

I could roughly guess why Jin Wikyung had sent him.

He was busy with his duties, so this was probably his way of looking after me.

“We’ve arrived.”

At last, we stopped in front of a two-story wooden building.

Wasn’t this the kind of building they called a pavilion in China? It had a distinctly old-fashioned charm.

“Wow.”

It was unbelievably spacious too. The moment the servant opened the door, my jaw dropped.

"Your bedroom is on the second floor. Bells have been installed throughout the building, so please ring one if you need anything."

Once the servant left, I collected myself and began exploring the pavilion. The first floor alone looked to be well over three hundred square meters.[41]

To someone who had lived in a goshiwon[42] room barely seven square meters[43] in size, it might as well have been an Olympic stadium.

This is the first time I've ever envied an NPC.

There were six rooms on the first floor alone. Curiosity suddenly surged through me.

What could be inside?

Treasures? Martial arts manuals? Amazing items?

I didn't care what it was. I flung open the nearest door.

"Whoa."

The exclamation slipped out the moment the door opened. There were no fluorescent lights, yet the room was bright—thanks to the silk clothes packed onto the shelves along the walls. There was an astonishing amount of them, even at a glance.

Of course, it wasn't what I was looking for.

This bastard owns a lot of clothes.

A club regular—no, a pleasure-house regular through and through. I clicked my tongue, closed the door, and went straight to the second room. Then I threw that door open too.

"More clothes?"

I had underestimated Jin Taekyung. At this point, he might as well have been the fashionista of his age.

Trying to ignore the unease creeping over me, I moved on to the third room.

The door flew open.

"…You fucking shopaholic."

Seriously, what the hell was wrong with this guy? Seeing three whole rooms crammed with clothes left me feeling like I had a sweet potato lodged in my throat.[44]

Could it be…

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[41] Three hundred square meters is about 3,200 square feet.

[42] A goshiwon is a small, inexpensive rented room, traditionally associated with students preparing for exams.

[43] Seven square meters is about 75 square feet.

[44] In Korean, the feeling of having eaten sweet potatoes can describe frustration or a sense of being stifled.

My unease was becoming real, growing heavier by the second. I trudged to the final room. Unlike the others, it clearly hadn't been used in a long time. I took hold of the rusty handle and slowly pushed.

Creeeak.

With an irritating groan, the final room revealed what lay inside.

Sunlight filtered through a small window. Dust rose with every step. And beyond it stood several bookshelves.

"Found it."

A smile spread across my face before I even realized it.

There were five bookshelves in total. I approached the nearest one and pulled out a book. When I brushed off the thick layer of dust, the writing on the cover appeared.

This was why the System was so convenient. Thanks to Synchronization, I could read and pronounce even writing that looked like an alien language as naturally as my mother tongue.

"Three-Turn Footwork?"

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Three-Turn Footwork
Type: Martial Arts Manual
Grade: Third Rate
Restriction: None
Description: The most basic practical footwork technique. It can even be purchased on the open market.
Would you like to train in this martial art? (3 / 10)

Yes!

My heart pounded as I read through the System window.

Three-Turn Footwork. The most basic third-rate footwork technique. This was it—the kind of martial arts manual I had only ever seen in novels.

My first plan was to learn martial arts.

So the System applies to martial arts training too.

The suspicion I had formed after completing the Quest to circulate my qi, just before coming to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, had now become certainty.

Thank goodness.

I had been worried that I might have to learn everything step by step, like the protagonists and NPCs in novels. Fortunately, that fear had proved unfounded.

Even a trash game is still a game.

If the System applied to ordinary martial arts the same way it had when I circulated my qi, rapid growth would be a piece of cake.

I was about to shout, “I accept!”—but stopped.

SYSTEM

Would you like to train in this martial art? (3 / 10)

The number in parentheses really bothered me. I had learned exactly three martial arts so far: the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique, the Jin Family’s Spear Technique, and the Jin Family’s Manoeuvre Technique.

Could it be…

Is there a limit to how many martial arts I can learn?

If that suspicion was true, now was not the time to learn a third-rate martial art like Three-Turn Footwork. I needed to find a higher-grade martial art—one that could keep me alive until Logout and help me raise my Level and Fame quickly.

The good news was that this room contained several hundred martial arts manuals, give or take.

“Good. Good.”

That meant I could learn seven more martial arts. If I filled those slots with nothing but the best techniques, Logout would only be a matter of time.

With a satisfied smile, I pulled out the next book.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
The Night King: Well-Endowed Man
Type: Erotic Novel
Grade: None
Restriction: None
Description: Even better when read with illustrations.

“…”

Today's battle against work had been fierce. Jin Wikyung had not left the office once since morning, and now it was nearly midnight. This grueling pace had already continued for two months.

"Thank you for your hard work."

Wipeng's words signaled the end of the day's work.

Jin Wikyung hauled his stiff body upright and left the office. After all, the owner of that room was not Jin Wikyung, but his father, who had suddenly vanished one day.

His residence was a pavilion in the inner compound at the center of the Jin Family estate, about a quarter hour away on foot.

"It's cold tonight."

Wipeng, who followed him like a shadow, draped a thick fur cloak over his shoulders. Jin Wikyung smiled tiredly.

"Thank you. Without you, I might have collapsed long ago."

"What choice do I have? Someone has to play the lady of the house."

"Don't start. The old men are already hounding me about it."

Jin Wikyung rubbed his gritty eyes. Though he was in his mid-thirties, he remained unmarried. He had kept putting marriage off on the grounds that he was still young, and those delays had added up to more than a decade.

I suppose I'll have to do it eventually. For the family's sake.

It wasn't as though he had never been in love.

But Jin Wikyung was no immature child. One day, he would become the Family Head and bear responsibility for everyone in the household. If a political marriage could strengthen the family, he considered it a small sacrifice to make.

"The stars are bright tonight. We almost didn't need torches."

Sensing his mood, Wipeng changed the subject. Jin Wikyung shook his head. His residence had already come into view.

"Hmm?"

"What is it?"

Following Jin Wikyung's gaze, Wipeng tilted his head. A faint light was leaking from a nearby pavilion.

"Isn't that the Third Young Master's residence?"

"It is. It's late, but the lights are still on."

As he spoke, Jin Wikyung strode forward. Wipeng had no choice but to follow.

"My lord, why don't we come back another time? He's only using the memory loss as an excuse. He's obviously in there drinking."

"Shh."

The two men entered the pavilion. The light came from the old room on the far left. Constant creaking sounded from within, as if someone were moving around nonstop.

“I underestimated the Third Young Master. It sounds like he even brought a woman in. Listen to that. I’ll bet this month’s salary on it.”

Wipeng’s lips moved. He was using Sound Transmission, sending his voice through internal energy.

“Wipeng.”

“Yes?”

“Shut your mouth.”

Jin Wikyung sent the short, heavy reply through Sound Transmission, then moved right up to the door. Through the open crack, he could see what was happening inside.

Then Wipeng cut in with a wounded expression.

“I never took you for this sort of person, my lord, but your tastes are rather unusual…”

He gasped.

The next moment, Wipeng’s mouth fell open.

What did I just see?

Am I seeing things because I’ve been feeling weak lately?

He rubbed his eyes with his sleeve, but all five senses kept insisting that the scene before him was real.

“Now, take two steps diagonally…”

A sturdy young man muttered to himself as he moved without rest. Countless footprints covered the dusty floor, and more were appearing even now.

Swish. Slip.

“Fuck, this martial art is designed like shiiiiit!”

It was the Third Young Master. That god-awful temper and that foul mouth. There was no doubt that he was Jin Taekyung.

He had not trained in martial arts since he was twelve, yet here he was, practicing past midnight until he was drenched in dust and sweat.

“Wipeng.”

Wipeng, who had been staring blankly, snapped back to his senses.

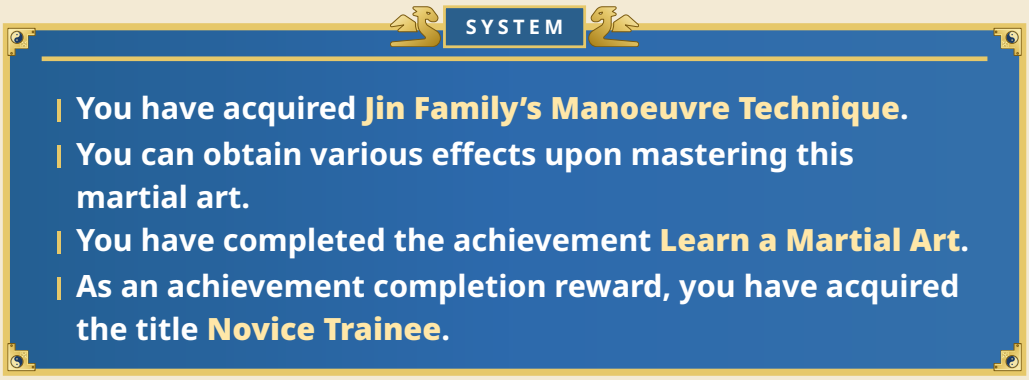
“Yes, yes?”

Jin Wikyung gazed into the room with dazed eyes. Jin Taekyung had fallen over and was hurling vicious curses at the ceiling, but he soon got back up and resumed practicing his footwork.

“As promised, you won’t be getting paid this month.”

Chapter 9

Ding.



"Good grief."

The moment the System notification appeared, I slumped to the floor. Dust billowed around me, but who cared? I already looked like a bum anyway.

Why is this so damn hard?

There were only two kinds of books in Jin Taekyung's study.

Erotic novels. And books that weren't erotic novels.

Of the more than four hundred books, only about a hundred remained after I took out the erotic novels.

What an incredible bastard.

If he'd been born in Korea, he would've run an illegal adult website. If he'd been born in the United States, he would've ended up in prison.

At any rate, once I finished sorting them, there were only about thirty martial arts manuals.

If only he'd collected half as many manuals as erotic novels.

It was a shame as far as I was concerned, but the search had still paid off. I'd found the martial arts manuals I needed right now.

The Jin Family's Spear Technique and the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique. They were hereditary martial arts of the Jin Family of Taiyuan—arts I'd forgotten because I hadn't practiced them in far too long.

Let's check the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Skill Window
Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique
Type: Manoeuvre Technique
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: Direct descendants of the Jin Family of Taiyuan
Realm: First Stage
Description: A manoeuvre technique devised by the founder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. It has few variations and is monotonous, but it is practical.

The description of the Jin Family's Spear Technique wasn't much different. Except…

Few variations and monotonous, my ass.

The hereditary martial art created by some fellow called the founder—or was it Archaeopteryx?—was insanely complicated. Just thinking about last night made me grind my teeth.

SYSTEM

You are beginning to acquire Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique.
You are memorizing the formula. The speed varies according to the martial art's grade and your Intelligence stat.

Right. Everything was fine up to that point.

The problem came next.

SYSTEM

The movement sequence for Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique is being displayed. (0 / 100)

I followed the footprints displayed by the System and practiced the manoeuvre technique, but it was incredibly strict. Step even slightly outside the footprints, and I failed. Take too long to perform the next movement, and I failed again.

I had to follow the entire sequence perfectly for it to count as one completion.

What a fucking garbage game.

There was a major difference between my real-world physique and this

character's. I was nearly half a handspan[45] shorter now, and my reach was shorter too. I couldn't make the fine adjustments I needed, so one mistake followed another.

It's a miracle I succeeded at all.

By the time I completed the sequence one hundred times, my hands and feet were trembling.

Still, I gained something.

After years of working as a Hunter, I was thoroughly familiar with combat—especially group battles. In a fight where life and death were on the line, the most important thing was luck first and your feet second.

Advance. Retreat. Or stop.

Even if you lost an arm, you could survive as long as your legs still moved. But if you lost your legs, it was over.

Your feet had to move before your arms. That was how every battle I'd fought had gone, and it was why I'd chosen to learn a manoeuvre technique first.

But…

This was too slow. Even with the System's help, more than half a day had flown by. How much longer would it take to learn the spear technique too?

This is already day five.

I'd heard that time passed faster in virtual-reality games than in the real world. But even after accounting for the time multiplier, five days was a long time.

"Phew…"

I sighed and forced the distracting thoughts from my mind.

Rescue? Logout?

This wasn't the time to cling to possibilities. I had to keep moving forward, even if I had to do it alone.

That's enough for today.

I gathered up the martial arts manuals and stood.

When I reached the bedroom on the second floor, I realized that one unusual book had been mixed in among them.

The Night King: Well-Endowed Man

"Ahem."

Oh dear. What a mistake.

"Are you up already?"

[45] A Korean handspan (*ppyeom*) is the distance between the tips of an outstretched thumb and little finger, roughly 20 cm (8 in). Half a handspan is about 10 cm (4 in).

The servant stared at me with wide eyes, a breakfast tray in his hands.

“I couldn’t sleep…”

It was the truth. Circulating my qi was to blame.

This is ridiculously effective.

Circulating my qi didn’t just clear my mind and sharpen my senses. It also relieved fatigue. Come to think of it, I didn’t think I’d felt tired even once since I started doing it.

The pain is almost gone too.

“Your wounds could worsen, so please don’t push yourself too hard.”

A warm feeling spread through my chest at the servant’s words. Even in this shitty game, there was an NPC who shone like a ray of light. I’d finally met a normal person.

Why is this enough to make me emotional?

Strangely choked up, I started on breakfast.

Every side dish was either too salty or too bland, but hunger made a fine seasoning. I polished off the meal, then downed the bowl of herbal medicine in one gulp.

“Ugh.”

The taste made me grimace. After clearing away the table, the servant bowed his head.

“Then I shall take my leave.”

“Ah, wait a second.”

“Please speak more casually to me. Why are you addressing me so respectfully?”

Come to think of it, he had a point.

At first, the graphics and artificial intelligence had been so realistic that I’d used polite speech with every NPC I met. By now, though, I’d grown somewhat accustomed to them.

The time had finally come to reclaim my dignity as a user.

I answered sternly.

“For now, I’ll speak however I’m comfortable.”

Fuck, I can’t bring myself to drop the honorifics.

I couldn’t exactly talk down to a man who clearly looked over forty and call him “you bastard” or “you punk.”

Damn game. The graphics were so good I couldn’t even speak informally.

At this rate, I’ll end up becoming buddies with an NPC.

When I emphasized that I’d suffered a head injury, the servant reluctantly nodded.

“I suppose it can’t be helped. Is there something you require?”

“I was wondering if there was an empty room.”

The servant tilted his head.

“I can arrange one for you, but what might you need it for?”

“I want to practice martial arts.”

“Pardon?”

“All the rooms here are either dirty or stuffy… Why do you look like that?”

After leaving the pavilion, the servant went straight to the Family Head’s office.

Once his report was finished, Jin Wikyung’s solemn voice rang out from behind a tower of documents.

“You’ve done well.”

The instant the servant left, Jin Wikyung sprang to his feet and flung the documents into the air.

“This calls for a celebration! I’m not working today!”

“Who said you could decide that?”

Wipeng caught every last fluttering sheet and sighed.

“If the others find out you’re acting like this, they’ll start talking again.”

“The Third Young Master says he’s going to take up martial arts in earnest. What could possibly be more important than that?”

“The fact that the Council of Elders is waiting to pounce on you is more important.”

At the words *Council of Elders*, Jin Wikyung’s expression darkened.

“Damn old men.”

“A family council meeting may be held soon. From their perspective, they’ve spotted an opening, so naturally they’ll sink their teeth into it.”

The agenda was obvious. It would begin with Jin Taekyung’s usual conduct and end with an attack on Jin Wikyung himself, the Lesser Family Head.

“Those bastards are persistent.”

“Is that anything new? Old pillars always end up crawling with bugs.”

“Isn’t there any way around it?”

“So you’re volunteering to serve as the Third Young Master’s shield again.”

Wipeng sighed.

“My lord, may I offer a word?”

“I refuse.”

“Then I refuse your refusal. This is the fifth time he’s embezzled the family’s public funds. I’ve lost count of everything else. If we’d enforced the family rules properly, it would be a miracle if the Third Young Master were still alive.”

“Now, now.”

“Since we’re on the subject, grab anyone in the family and ask them. To you, he’s your beloved little brother. To everyone else… Honestly, I can’t even say it.”

“Do you have something against my youngest brother? Why are you talking like that?”

“Because I’m frustrated. That’s why. The Third Young Master causes trouble, you clean it up, and then you give in to the Council of Elders’ demands to keep them from making things worse. They’re slowly stripping away your authority. Do you know what kind of rumor is going around these days?”

“What rumor?”

“Some people say the Third Young Master is part of the Elder faction. That he gets pocket money from the Council of Elders and deliberately causes trouble.”

Jin Wikyung’s eyelids twitched.

“That’s an outrage!”

“I’d actually prefer that to be true. If the Council of Elders slipped him even a few silver coins, he wouldn’t have to embezzle the family’s funds.”

“You…”

“I’ve said my piece. Fire me if you want.”

Groaning, Jin Wikyung let out a deep sigh.

“I’ve been thinking things can’t go on like this either.”

“Thinking is good. The problem is that you never act on it.”

“Even so, I should do everything I can this time.”

“Oh, my lord…”

“This will be the last time. I give you my word.”

Jin Wikyung’s expression turned serious. Wipeng asked skeptically,

“Do you really mean it?”

“He’s still a child, and his memory hasn’t fully returned. Besides… he became a completely different person overnight. You’ve noticed it too.”

“That’s true, but…”

Wipeng trailed off.

The Third Young Master had definitely changed. Whether his memory loss was real or a lie, the way he was behaving now gave them reason to hope.

Jin Wikyung thought for a moment, then spoke.

“Wipeng.”

“Yes.”

“Prepare an order in my name.”

“What sort of order?”

“Use a few suitable charges and order him into indefinite confinement in the training hall.”

“Ah.”

Wipeng slapped his forehead.

It was mostly for show, but under the circumstances, it was an excellent emergency measure. It would ease the pressure Jin Wikyung was bound to face at the upcoming family council meeting while keeping Jin Taekyung’s punishment relatively light.

And on top of that…

“It also fulfills the Third Young Master’s request. He was looking for somewhere to train.”

Wasn’t that three birds with one stone? Wipeng was genuinely impressed.

“As expected of you, my lord.”

“That’s how my family is. Oh, did I ever tell you? Taekyung was such a clever child. One day, when he was young…”

“…I’ll go write the order.”

“Therefore, for violating fourteen regulations and disrupting discipline within the family, the Third Young Master, Jin Taekyung, is hereby ordered to undergo indefinite confinement in the training hall.”

Was his name Wipeng? I listened silently to the unpleasant-looking bastard, then raised my hand.

“I have a question.”

“Go ahead.”

“What does ‘indefinite’ mean?”

Wipeng answered reluctantly.

“It means there is no set deadline.”

“Oh.”

I’d thought the game’s language system had malfunctioned. Fortunately, it meant exactly what I thought it meant.

Ha ha.

“Ha ha ha.”

“Ho ho ho.”

Laughter was contagious. The warriors who’d come with Wipeng started laughing along with me.

In that warm atmosphere, Wipeng read the final line.

“The convict, Jin Taekyung, shall submit to the bonds.”

“No.”

“…”

"…"

"I said no. Fuck."

The two men approaching with binding ropes looked at Wipeng as if to say, *This isn't how it was supposed to go.*

I ignored them and said what I had to say.

"I asked you to find me a room so I could practice. I didn't ask you to put me in prison."

Are these bastards completely insane?

"Now, Third Young Master. Calm down and listen to me."

"Listen, my ass. 'The training hall has everything you need for practice. The living conditions aren't bad either.' You're just going to spout that kind of nonsense."

Judging by Wipeng's expression, I'd hit the nail on the head. I drove the point home.

"You're the kind of bastards who'd tell someone to enjoy military service because soldiers got a pay raise. Forget it. I'm not going in. I'll practice by myself in my room or in the yard."

Honestly, when I thought about it in isolation, the training hall didn't sound so bad.

But the word *indefinite* stuck in my mind like a thorn. I urgently needed to learn martial arts and Level up. I couldn't spend forever in the training hall, craning my neck and waiting for someone to let me out.

I flopped onto the floor.

"Go ahead and gut me!"

"Third Young Master, that's enough. Please get up."

Wipeng scowled down at me.

"The Lesser Family Head made this decision entirely for your sake."

"Jin Wikyung—I mean, my brother?"

That brother-obsessed idiot had given this order?

At that moment, Wipeng's lips moved. A voice reached my ears at the same time, carrying a strange sensation unlike ordinary speech.

"This is Sound Transmission. Don't be alarmed. Just listen."

Sound Transmission. I remembered reading about it in martial arts novels. A kind of telepathy that only masters could use.

"You may not know this because you've lost your memory, but the Third Young Master is considered a serious troublemaker. A harsher punishment may be handed down soon, so the Lesser Family Head is taking action before that happens."

I'd worked hard all twenty-seven years of my life. How had I ended up facing an even harsher punishment?

As I lamented my fate, Wipeng's Sound Transmission continued in my ear.

"It may be called indefinite confinement, but do you really think the Lesser Family Head intends to bury you in the training hall for the rest of your life?"

I shook my head.

There's no way he'd do that.

Not unless he wanted the two of us locked up together in the training hall.

"I'll get you out within seven days and nights at the latest. How does that sound?"

There was fierce determination in Wipeng's eyes. If I refused this too, he looked ready to beat me and drag me there if he had to.

Fuck, are all the NPCs here thugs or what?

Hey, asshole. Are you really that good at fighting?

I raised my Qi Sense and checked Wipeng's Level.

"…"

He really is a thug.

A Level thug, at least.

He was probably every bit the human butcher Jin Wikyung was.

Wipeng's eyes widened as he asked,

"What will you do?"

Even as I trembled with fear, I held up three fingers.

"…You want me to get you out in three days?"

What kind of bastard is this?

Wipeng glared at me with that exact look, then finally sighed.

"Escort him."

#TrainingHall #ClosedDoorTraining #Negotiation #Successful.

Chapter 10

After walking for more than ten minutes, we arrived at a cliff that sealed off the rear of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. A massive cavern gaped open in its face, and one man stood before it.

“Hmm. So you’ve come.”

He had the build of a brown bear and spoke in a solemn tone.

Jin Wikyung.

I bowed awkwardly.

“Hello, hyung[46]… sir.”

Jin Wikyung made me uncomfortable. As if suddenly acquiring an NPC family wasn’t enough, he paid an absurd amount of attention to me.

Just look at him. He was trying desperately not to show it with everyone watching, but if you looked closely, his eyes were moist.

Is this guy seriously that sentimental?

He looked like he could make even a triad[47] boss back down, yet somehow every character in this game was completely bizarre.

“I can no longer overlook your conduct. As the Lesser Family Head and acting Family Head, I have ordered you into closed-door confinement. Do you have anything to say?”

Of course I do.

But this was all a staged performance. On the way to the training hall, Wipeng had explained what was really going on. There was a power struggle among the upper ranks of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and Jin Wikyung was shielding me from it.

In other words, this forced confinement was all for show.

“The Young Master needed a place to train anyway, didn’t he? Just endure it for three days.”

Remembering Wipeng’s final words, I bowed my head and pretended to repent.

“I will gladly accept my punishment.”

The best thing about this play was how short my lines were.

Jin Wikyung delivered his final line with sorrow in his eyes.

“Confine the criminal to the training hall. The date of his release will be announced later.”

The moment he finished speaking, two warriors guarding the entrance to the training hall approached and grabbed me by both arms.

The play was over. Time to exit the stage.

I stood at the entrance to the training hall.

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[46] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for his older brother or an older man he is close to.

[47] A triad is a Chinese organized-crime group.

I've had everything you need brought there. Little brother, don't overdo it.

With Jin Wikyung's Sound Transmission in my ear, I took my first step inside.

The training hall was, in a word, a cave. An artificial cave carved into the cliff, at that.

It was tall, spacious, and damp.

Splash. Splash.

I followed one of the training hall's warriors deeper inside. By the time I could no longer tell whether I was wearing leather shoes or wet mops, a massive iron gate appeared before us.

Wow…

My mouth fell open the moment I saw it. The gate filled the passage from edge to edge, making it look less like a door than a wall built to prevent anyone from entering or leaving.

The warrior guiding me raised his torch and shouted, "Open the gate!"

Grrrnnng—

The massive iron gate slowly opened its jaws. It wasn't some magic command like "Open Sesame." An NPC waiting nearby had simply pulled a protruding lever that operated the gate.

Even so, it was an overwhelming sight.

And the moment I saw what lay beyond—

"Whoa."

This time, I couldn't suppress the exclamation that escaped me.

When I first entered the training hall, I had imagined nothing more than a damp underground cave, but…

"What is all this?"

There was a broad bed with a fur blanket that lifted my spirits just by looking at it. In place of a damp, uneven stone floor, a smooth gray surface stretched across the chamber.

Cement… Obviously not. Limestone?

Aside from the chill in the air—and even taking that into account—it was far nicer than I had imagined.

This is supposed to be a punishment?

As I stared around in a daze, someone cleared his throat behind me. I turned to find the warrior who had guided me here.

"We've prepared everything you'll need. Then I'll be on my way."

Grrrnnng.

I watched the iron gate slowly close with another grinding sound, then suddenly remembered the Sound Transmission I had heard at the entrance to the training hall.

I've had everything you need brought there. Little brother, don't overdo it.

Ah, the heart of an NPC who cared for his little brother.

This unworthy user wept his eyes out.

It was something that happened all the time in the real world, too. High-ranking officials who had committed corruption showing up at the prosecutors' office in wheelchairs, or checking themselves into private hospital rooms to avoid investigation.

My circumstances were a little different, but the arrangement was much the same. Deeply moved, I surveyed my private suite in the training hall.

"So this is the life of a gold spoon."[48]

It wasn't only the graphics and artificial intelligence that were realistic. The game also carried the social message that, no matter how high you flew or how low you crawled, gold spoons[49] had it best.

Seriously, what would I have done without this character? His father was the Family Head, his eldest brother was the Lesser Family Head, and his second brother was a martial arts prodigy. No wonder he could spend every day loafing around pleasure houses without a care in the world.

Jin Taekyung, you bastard…

Now that I thought about it, wasn't he actually some great sage who had grasped the ways of the world at a young age?

Shuddering at the realistic God-Spoon[50] System, I walked around the training hall, which covered a little over a hundred pyeong.[51] Before long, I found the "necessities" the warrior had mentioned.

Food first.

The food was stored in two jars. When I looked inside, I found rice balls that gave off a strong medicinal scent.

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[48] In Korean, "gold spoon" refers to someone born into wealth; "God-Spoon" plays on the expression to suggest an even more fortunate birth.

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[50] In Korean, "gold spoon" refers to someone born into wealth; "God-Spoon" plays on the expression to suggest an even more fortunate birth.

[51] A *pyeong* is a unit of area equal to 3.31 m^2 (35.6 ft^2). A little over a hundred pyeong is roughly 330 m^2 (3,600 ft^2).

SYSTEM

Item Window
Excellent Fasting Pill
Type: Pill
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: None
Description: A fasting pill made by crudely cramming in all kinds of beneficial medicinal ingredients. Restores vitality when consumed and grants additional effects with prolonged use.

"Oh, so these are the famous fasting pills?"

I had seen them plenty of times in martial arts novels. They were light, compact, easy to carry, and apparently provided nutritional supplementation, too.

The other jar was packed with fasting pills too.

I should put these in my inventory for now.

I grabbed the two jars and muttered, "Acquire items."

Anyone watching would have fallen over in shock. The two perfectly ordinary jars vanished as if they had evaporated.

I gazed fondly at them inside my inventory.

That takes care of food.

The second necessity I found was water. Since the training hall was, after all, a cave, a cold underground spring in one corner took care of my drinking water.

Then came the third and final necessity.

"Hmm."

A weapons rack held several weapons in a neat row. Naturally, the first thing I picked up was a sturdy-looking wooden spear.

Item appraisal.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Training Wooden Spear
Type: Weapon
Grade: Third Rate
Restriction: None
Description: Made for beginners.

"Oh."

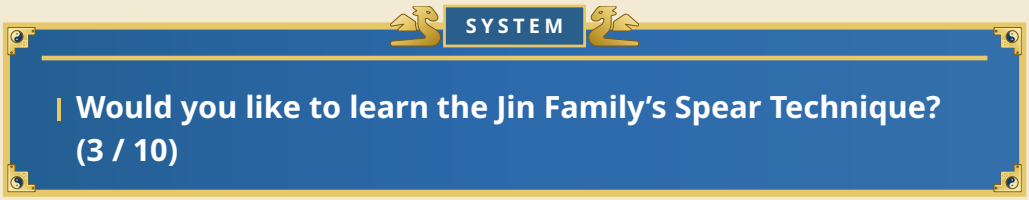
A wooden training spear made for beginners. It was exactly what I needed right now.

If I had just one more thing, everything would be perfect.

“Open inventory.”

Grinning, I took a martial arts manual titled *Jin Family’s Spear Technique* out of my inventory.

Ding.



“Obviously.”

The System was great.

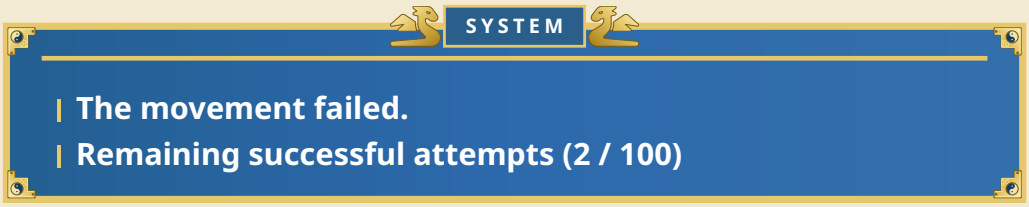
Sometimes, it was even adorable.

Yesterday, while learning the Jin Family’s Manoeuvre Technique, I had discovered something for the first time.

Ding wasn’t the System’s only notification sound.

I had also discovered just how much I hated the other one.

Beep!



The failure message. The System window that appeared without fail whenever I botched a movement.

I had no idea how many times I had seen it by now.

I stared at the *Training Wooden Spear* in my hand.

I was thinking about this all wrong.

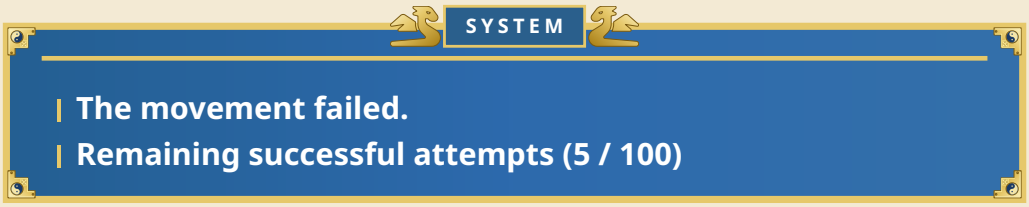
Maybe because it was made of wood, the spear was light. Whether I thrust or swung it, it moved fast.

That was the problem.

It’s too light to control.

The slightest adjustment was difficult, so I kept slipping up. There was no chance this damn nitpicky System would overlook even the tiniest mistake.

Beep.



“Ah, fuck.”

In the end, I tossed the *Training Wooden Spear* aside and pulled the *Sharp Spear* from my inventory. Its length and shaft thickness were roughly the same as the spear I had used in the real world.

So why hadn’t I taken it out from the start?

“It’s fucking heavy. Seriously.”

The entire thing was solid steel, so its weight was no joke. By feel alone, the monster had to weigh nearly fifty kilograms.[52]

My Stamina wouldn’t hold out if I swung something like this for hours.

My current realm was Second Rate. Even with the System’s help, there was no way I could whirl around more than half a sack of rice like a pinwheel.

It’s not like the strength of a tiger is suddenly going to well up inside me.

That was when it hit me.

“…Huh?”

What had I just said?

The strength of a tiger?

“I do have it.”

This was a game. It had a System and stats.

And it had internal energy.

Ten years of internal energy that I could draw out through a cultivation technique!

It was embarrassing that I had forgotten about it even for a moment.

“I should’ve tried using that…”

They say you only know what something is like once you’ve experienced it. Was it any wonder an F-rank Hunter was F-rank? With barely any mana to speak of, I made do with my bare body. Even among Hunters, I was treated like a half-baked amateur.

At least that solves one problem.

I laughed in disbelief and picked up the spear. Then, slowly and carefully, I began drawing out my internal energy.

[52] Fifty kilograms is about 110 lb.

The formula of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, imprinted in my mind by the System, rapidly played through my thoughts, guiding my internal energy along its prescribed path.

A prickling sensation ran through me.

The response was immediate.

The ten years of internal energy coiled in my dantian spread throughout my body. Because this was a game and I was a martial artist, I could feel that energy reaching every part of me.

This is…

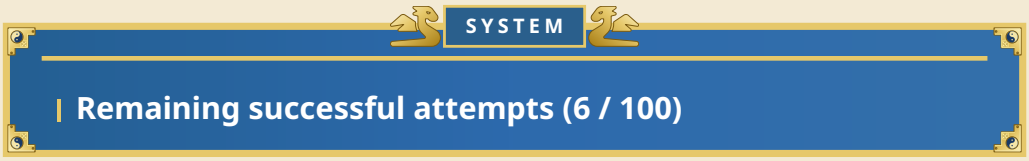
Strength overflowed through my entire body. My vastly improved physical abilities and senses once again filled me with exhilaration after my life as an F-rank Hunter.

I can change this much?

I gripped the spear and performed the *Jin Family's Spear Technique*. The fifty-kilogram[53] iron spear no longer felt heavy. Following my will, it thrust and slashed through the air.

Before long—

Ding.



At last, the notification I had been waiting for began to ring.

Jin Wikyung spoke with concern written across his face.

"He's doing well, isn't he?"

"He should be, if he has any sense of shame."

"He still hasn't fully recovered… He'll be all right, won't he?"

"Anyone who didn't know better would think the Third Young Master was on death's door. A little spit would fix him right up."

"No. You only say that because you don't know how frail the youngest was as a child."

Wipeng stared at him in disbelief.

"The elixirs and tonics that have gone into the Third Young Master could fill an entire room. And have you already forgotten the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng theft last year?"

[53] Fifty kilograms is about 110 lb.

“Ahem. That was…”

“The Medicine King Hall Master was so furious that he ran around threatening to cut open the Third Young Master’s stomach. To be honest, even while I was restraining him, I found myself thinking that cutting him open would count as self-defense.”

Jin Wikyung quietly looked away.

The matter had eventually been settled with compensation paid from Jin Wikyung’s personal fortune, but the Medicine King Hall Master’s fury at the time had been extraordinary.

“He swallowed that much elixir. Whatever else may be true, he probably won’t suffer from minor ailments until the day he dies.”

“It still isn’t enough. Can’t you tell just by looking at him? Every time I see the youngest, I feel sorry for him. He looks like a skeleton with a few scraps of flesh stuck to it. He’s so feeble and weak every morning.”

“No strength?”

Wipeng suddenly remembered a rumor he had once heard.

Among the courtesans of Taiyuan’s red-light district, Jin Taekyung was supposedly known as the Night King.

Just how impressive is he?

It seemed all that medicine had worked after all. Without realizing it, Wipeng raised his forearm and tried to imagine the size.

“What are you doing?”

“Ah, nothing.”

Jin Wikyung sighed as he looked over the mountain of documents piled before him.

“Between the youngest and everything happening inside and outside the family, there’s no end to my worries. Especially… the fact that ‘they’ have contacted us bothers me.”

“You mean the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

The Mount Heng Sword Sect.

The weight of that name was anything but light.

Ever since an undefeated wandering martial artist hung up its signboard decades ago, the sect had grown at a terrifying pace. By now, it was powerful enough to threaten the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s position.

“What do they intend?”

“I’ve sent my subordinates to investigate.”

Jin Wikyung toyed with the letter from the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Why were they coming? What did they want?

One question led to another, until he arrived at a single conclusion.

“Notify every branch in Shanxi Province. Whatever the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s purpose may be, tell them to prepare for every possibility.”

This was Murim.

Only those who were prepared would survive to see tomorrow.

Chapter 11

Whoosh. Fwoom—

The spearhead pierced dozens of glittering points in the air one after another.

Each time I completed a form, the red tassel hanging beneath the spearhead whipped around. It wasn't just for show. It was meant to distract the enemy.

Bang!

Again, the sound of wind being torn apart rang out. It was the seventh and final form of the Jin Family's Spear Technique: the Sky-Piercing Strike.

And this Sky-Piercing Strike was more precise and powerful than the ninety-nine I had successfully performed before it.

That's it.

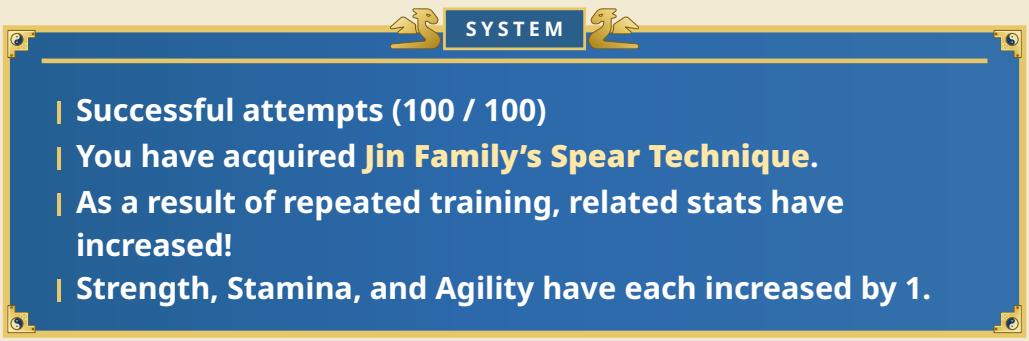
My fingertips tingled. Each of the seven forms of the Jin Family's Spear Technique was destructive enough on its own, but their true power emerged when they flowed together.

If I compared it to a car race, the first form started the engine, while the final Sky-Piercing Strike crossed the finish line.

"Whew."

I exhaled a hot breath and brought the spear upright.

Ding.



"Oh. My stats went up."

So this was another way to raise my stats. Intrigued, I opened my Status Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 11 Jin Taekyung
Occupation: Second Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 10
Titles: 3 (Title effects active)
| **Child of a Prestigious Family:** All stats +5, Fame +50
| **Shame of the Family:** All stats –5, Fame –50
| **Novice Trainee:** Training speed +10%
Strength: 41
Stamina: 51
Agility: 51
Intelligence: 10
Charm: 10
Internal Energy: 10 years
Remaining Points: 0

At this point…

“What a fine second-rate nobody.”

Still, it was better than reality. Here, I could keep climbing. I didn’t feel the limits I’d run up against every day since awakening as an F-rank, or the glass ceiling society had placed over me.

“So what? I can’t even log out whenever I want.”

I sighed and sank to the floor. After training nonstop for several hours, my body felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton.

“Man, I’m exhausted.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

| **You feel fatigued and hungry. Consume food to restore your physical condition.**

Yeah. I figured as much.

“Fatigue and hunger…”

There was only one answer: rest. Eat well and sleep well. But I couldn’t afford to lounge around scratching my belly.

If only I had some kind of recovery item…

“Oh, right. The fasting pills.”

I took a fasting pill from my Inventory. It gave off a strange smell, but a professional Hunter couldn't afford to be picky about whether his rice was hot or cold.

I opened my mouth wide and took a huge bite.

Then I thought,

Should I just spit it out?

It wasn't merely tasteless. It was so vile that my tongue screamed for mercy and my stomach put up a no-entry sign.

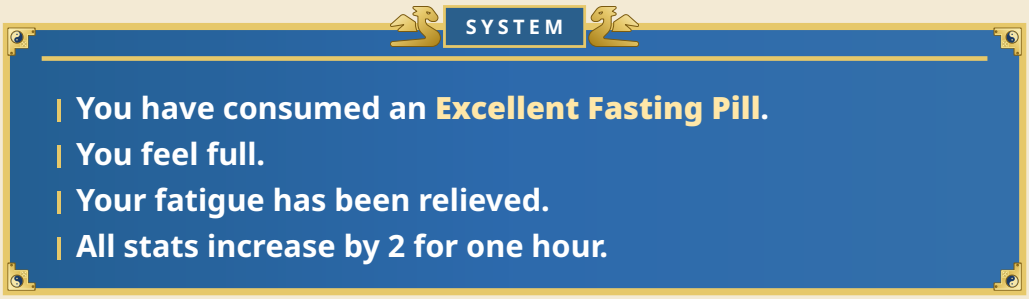
But humans could sometimes summon superhuman willpower. I squeezed my eyes shut, chewed the entire fasting pill, and forced it down.

Gulp.

"Uuugh. I ate it. I actually ate it."

If the System notification hadn't sounded the next moment, I probably would have kept rolling around on the floor for quite a while.

Ding.



"What?"

I hurriedly opened my Status Window. Every stat except Internal Energy had increased by 2. On top of that, my fatigue and hunger were both gone.

Feeling completely refreshed and comfortably full, I muttered,

"This is totally broken."

Who would have thought such a foul-tasting lump of grain could have such incredible effects?

Wait a second.

"Do the effects stack?"

Just one had raised my stats by a total of ten points. What if I ate two? Three? No, ten?

Even if that were goblin shit, I'd eat it.

Though goblin shit might actually taste better... Still, it was definitely worth trying.

I can do this. I can do this. Jin Taekyung.

With trembling hands, I picked up a second fasting pill.

A short while later—

SYSTEM

You have consumed an Excellent Fasting Pill.
The effects do not stack.
You feel excessively full.
Your movements will be slowed for one hour due to Overeating!

As the System notification sounded, I dropped to my knees.

“Bleaaargh!”

I could only resume training after my bloated stomach finally went down. I had three days to stay in the training hall. I needed to grow as strong as possible before leaving.

“Hah!”

With a short shout, the spearhead traced a heavy arc.

Keep my stance low, my feet heavy, and my spear fast.

The Jin Family’s Spear Technique was aggressive. It advanced relentlessly, keeping constant pressure on the enemy. Its movements were simple but lethal.

Didn’t it originate in the military?

I didn’t know the details of the game’s setting, but this didn’t seem like a martial art an ordinary foot soldier would learn.

It was a first-rate martial art, after all, and required considerable physical ability to perform. Maybe it had been practiced by elite soldiers or commanders.

Compared with what I learned at the Hunter training camp, it’s like heaven and earth.

Just then, my feet got tangled—whether from exhaustion or distraction, I couldn’t tell. Once my footwork fell apart, my hands followed. The spearhead, brimming with power, lost its momentum and sliced weakly through the air.

Whoosh—

The System sounded at the same time.

SYSTEM

Jin Family’s Spear Technique Mastery increased by 1. (6 / 100)

“Only 1?”

My Mastery increased each time I performed the martial art from beginning to end. The amount depended on the System's evaluation, and this time I'd only gained 1 because my feet kept getting tangled.

"Why am I getting worse the more I do this?"

This was the third time I'd performed the Jin Family's Spear Technique since acquiring it, and each attempt had been worse than the last. The first had earned me 3 Mastery. The second, 2. Now the third had given me 1.

"Three, two, one. What is this, a countdown?"

At this rate, the fourth attempt wouldn't give me any Mastery at all. I sighed and gripped the spear again. My breath was growing ragged, but I performed the Jin Family's Spear Technique once more.

Around the fourth form, I lost my balance and fell.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You did not gain Mastery for Jin Family's Spear Technique. (6 / 100)

"This is driving me insane."

I stayed flat on my back and stared at the stalactites hanging from the training hall's ceiling.

My feet kept getting tangled. I was performing the technique exactly as I had learned it, so why was this happening? Nothing like this had happened when I acquired it.

"What's the problem?"

Something kept catching and throwing me off. I had to figure out what it was.

I got back up like a roly-poly and performed the Jin Family's Spear Technique again. This time, I fell after only the third form.

SYSTEM

You did not gain Mastery for Jin Family's Spear Technique. (6 / 100)

When I focused on my feet instead of the spear, the problem began to reveal itself.

Good. One more time.

SYSTEM

You did not gain Mastery for Jin Family's Spear Technique. (6 / 100)

Now I understood. But…

"Why is the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique showing up here?"

I had struggled when I first learned it. I'd spent half a day practicing nothing but footwork. But had I practiced it enough to unconsciously mix it into my spear technique?

No.

By that logic, I'd be mixing in every movement I've learned over the past seven years.

I had learned spear fighting before, too. It was one of the basics taught at the Hunter training camp. Since it was distributed to F-ranks who couldn't use mana, we called it shitty spear fighting among ourselves.

Compared with that, the Jin Family's Spear Technique was good enough for intermediate Hunters.

"Should I give it a try?"

No matter how hard I racked my brain, all I'd get was a bald spot. The only way to understand a technique was to try it with my whole body.

I slowly began performing the Jin Family's Spear Technique. At the same time, I used the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique with my lower body.

The movements feel unnatural.

They kept falling out of sync. But this was different. Before, it had felt like a mass of tangled threads. Now it felt like two gears missing each other by the slightest fraction.

How many times did I try?

Whoosh—Bang!

It was a simple thrust. For a moment, I wondered if I had somehow performed all the way through the seventh and final form without realizing it, but it was only one movement from the fifth form.

"What was that?"

A shiver ran down my spine. For a single instant, the footwork and spear technique had meshed perfectly. The spear in my hand quivered.

SYSTEM

You did not gain Mastery for Jin Family's Spear Technique. (6 / 100)

I shoved the System notification into a corner of my mind and tightened my grip on the spear. Recalling the sensation from a moment ago, I stepped forward.

And tried again.

Swish—Whoosh—

This is it.

I felt it the instant I thrust the spear.

The footwork and spear technique—the two gears meshed perfectly.

An indescribable thrill swept over me as I turned those two gears again and again. Every step I took was fast and precise. Every thrust, slash, and sweep of the spear was fast, precise, and powerful.

My dantian grew hot. My internal energy became a ball of fire and seeped into the spear.

I had to unleash it.

Now!

"Hah!"

The Sky-Piercing Strike—the final blow of the Jin Family's Spear Technique, said to pierce the heavens—shot forward.

A deep, muffled boom erupted through the cavern.

Boom!

Dust billowed, and fragments of stone flew in every direction. The spear embedded in the training hall's wall trembled. A massive hole had formed around the spearhead, which had sunk so deep that it was no longer visible.

A hole?

No. This was a crater.

The sight took my breath away.

"Huff, huff…"

The exhilaration sent a shiver down my spine.

Fuck, that was me. I did that!

I had unleashed that insane strike—the kind that could take down a Troll in one blow.

Me!

I staggered.

Huh?

I needed to shout at the top of my lungs and take a picture as proof. I needed to wipe the smirk off Jinho hyung's[54] face for calling me Rice Weevil.

Oh, right. I'm in a game.

[54] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

My vision blurred. The strength drained from my body. An unbearable wave of drowsiness washed over me.

I'm sleepy.

I stopped thinking and surrendered to instinct. A familiar sound faded into the distance.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

.

.

.

SYSTEM

All internal energy has been depleted.
You feel extreme fatigue.
You have completed the achievement Unity of Self and Object. A reward will be granted!
You have realized the connection between martial arts on your own. As a reward, the realms of your martial arts will rise substantially.
The realm of Jin Family's Cultivation Technique...
The realm of Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique...
The realm of Jin Family's Spear Technique...
Level up!
Level up!

SYSTEM

Sleep mode has ended.

I opened my eyes. The cave ceiling came into view, stalactites hanging overhead.

The training hall.

How long had I been unconscious? Half a day? A full day?

I didn't know. What mattered was that I was still inside the game and had gotten plenty of rest.

I feel great, too.

My body felt strangely good. Come to think of it, I vaguely remembered hearing System notifications just before I passed out.

"Open Message Window."

The next moment, unread messages filled my vision. By the time I finished reading them and sorting through my thoughts, more than ten minutes had passed.

I muttered a brief reaction.

“I hit the jackpot.”

The Jin Family’s Manoeuvre Technique and Spear Technique had both risen to the Third Stage—a jump of two whole stages. The Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique had reached the Second Stage.

And on top of that…

“I went up two Levels?”

I was happy, but also bewildered. I hadn’t seriously expected to Level up in the training hall.

“Don’t you usually Level up by completing Quests or killing monsters?”

Apparently, learning martial arts and gaining insight like this could also make me Level up. Was it because this was a martial-arts game? I really couldn’t predict anything here.

“No wonder I feel so light.”

The Level Ups must have restored my condition. Even the bruises and lingering aches I’d had before leveling up were completely gone.

“Open Status Window.”

The Status Window had changed too. Reaching Level 13 had given me twenty remaining points, and my training had slightly increased my Strength, Stamina, and Agility.

“Level 13…”

The Quest completion requirements were reaching the first-rate realm, Level 30, and 500 Fame.

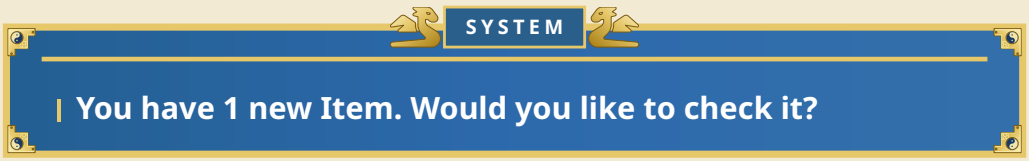
I wasn’t progressing quickly, but I was steadily leveling up through training alone. That meant I was cruising along.

Once I get out of the training hall, I can raise the sails and really take off.

I smiled contentedly and distributed my points.

Now all that remained was to check the reward I’d received for completing the **Unity of Self and Object** achievement.

“Open Inventory.”



Yeah. Hand it over.

Chapter 12

Was it about ten years ago? Back when I was in high school, several dozen ordinary people entered a Gate with government approval.

China, I think.

A Gate was the kind of place where even Hunters could end up dead the moment they let their guard down, yet they were sending ordinary people inside? It really was the Miracle Continent.

On the day of the expedition ceremony when this insane stunt took place, their identities were revealed during an interview with the overseas press.

The Chinese Martial Arts Alliance.

In other words, they were modern-day Murim martial artists. Made up entirely of non-awakened people, they stood before hundreds of cameras with their robes fluttering and solemnly declared:

Today, Zhonghua's[55] thousand-year martial lineage will be reborn in all its glory.

It certainly was glorious. Less than half a day later, their faces were plastered across the front pages of news outlets everywhere.

> **Chinese Martial Arts Alliance: Twenty-Five Members Massacred in an F-Rank Gate. More Than Half Confirmed Dead from Goblin Poison Needles…**

I didn't know how impressive a thousand-year martial lineage was supposed to be, but the incident humiliated China, and the Chinese Martial Arts Alliance was left with nothing but its signboard.

They got completely wrecked.

Some of the continent's most renowned martial artists were killed by goblin poison needles, while a tai chi master got beaten senseless by a mixed martial arts fighter.

That was reality. I had always thought the scenes in novels and movies were fiction dressed up by the media and wrapped in a veil of mystery.

But…

Now, I wasn't so sure. The movements Hyuk Mujin had shown me were *real*.

As I learned martial arts myself, my doubts gradually hardened into certainty. There was nothing weak or floppy about the martial arts here, unlike the ones in reality.

The martial arts of this world were systematic and incorporated countless movements. Real-world martial arts and boxing couldn't even compare.

[55] *Zhonghua* is a Chinese term for China and its people, often used to express national identity.

How is this possible? Is it simply because this is a game?

Ssshh. Hooouu.

As I breathed, I sensed the energy outside my body and drew it in.

Compared to the ten years of internal energy rotating through my acupoints, it was nothing but a speck of dust—small and weak. But I was in no position to complain about even that.

One circuit. Two…

I continued circulating my qi according to the formula of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique. It came naturally, as if I had been practicing it since childhood.

Gyeonjeong, Amun, Bongan, Ip-dong…

Names of acupoints I had never heard of in all my twenty-seven years surfaced and vanished in my mind. Hundreds of them had been engraved into my memory like that. Just how far did the System's capabilities extend?

Now that I think about it, it's downright bizarre.

The human brain wasn't a computer. Yet the System had entered the information into my mind as if it were copying and pasting a file. The same was true of the other martial arts.

Was something like this really possible just because this was a game?

No. Focus on circulating qi for now.

I steadied my breathing and guided my internal energy once more. Only after circulating all ten years of internal energy through twelve complete circuits according to the formula of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique did I open my eyes.

Ding.

SYSTEM

| You have completed Circulating Qi.
| Jin Family's Cultivation Technique Mastery has increased slightly.
| A small amount of turbid qi has been expelled.

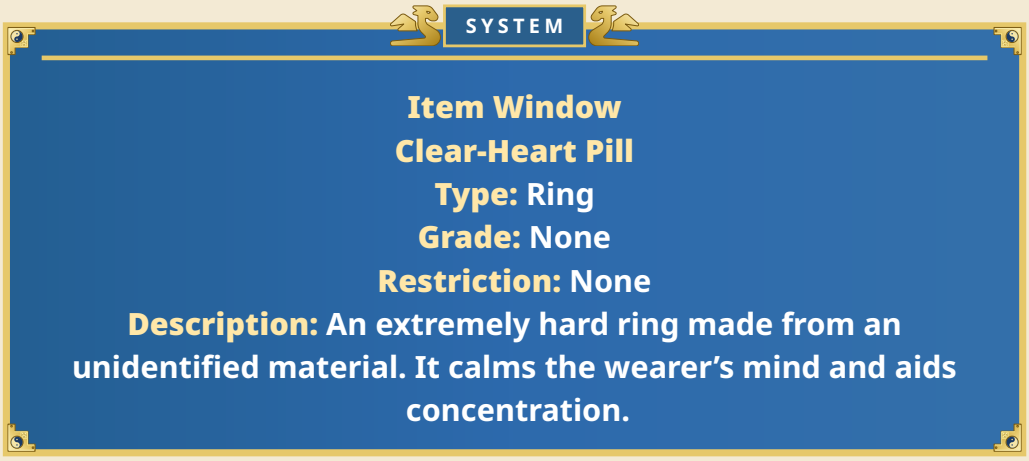
"Whew."

The Third Stage of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was within reach. I didn't know whether it was because I had started from the very bottom, but my progress felt fairly fast.

Or it could be thanks to the Item.

I looked at the ring on my right middle finger.

It was the Item I had received as a Reward for completing the **Unity of Self and Object** achievement.



The Clear-Heart Pill.[56] It looked different from the one I knew, but its effects were similar. Ever since I put it on, it had taken me less time to settle into circulating qi, and the Mastery I gained had increased.

It's good, but…

I couldn't shake the uneasy feeling. I could chalk Logout up to some technical wizardry by engineers whose work I couldn't begin to understand. But the martial arts formulas and this ring—the Clear-Heart Pill—made me uncomfortable in a way I couldn't quite explain.

Was I supposed to call it the feeling of something being forcibly injected into me?

They might help me survive, but that didn't make it a pleasant experience. This game was a piece of shit in more ways than one.

"What the hell is Seong Jinho doing? Some goshiwon[57] manager he is."

If he'd gotten up, he should have woken me so we could at least have a bowl of hangover soup. And yet, the fact that nothing had changed even now meant…

No. That's not it.

At the very least, I was still alive in the real world. That was why I could still exist in this game as a player.

I was alive in reality and in the game. And I would make it out alive, no matter what. I had too much to live for and too many burdens on my shoulders to die a pointless death here.

I can't die here.

I clenched my teeth and sat cross-legged. Perhaps it was the Clear-Heart Pill's effect, but my mind gradually settled and my breathing steadied.

---

[56] A cheongsimhwan is a traditional Korean herbal pill used to calm the nerves.

[57] A goshiwon is an inexpensive boarding house made up of tiny private rooms, often rented by students preparing for exams.

As the internal energy in my dantian began to stir, I started yet another session of circulating qi.

It was my second day in the training hall.

I devoted myself to training without rest. I practiced the Spear Technique and Manoeuvre Technique like a madman, and whenever I completely exhausted my internal energy, I immediately began circulating qi.

Ding.

SYSTEM

The realm of Jin Family's Cultivation Technique has risen to the Third Stage.

Your internal energy has become purer, allowing you to circulate qi more efficiently.

The Third Stage of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique. My progress had been slower than with the other two, but it wasn't bad.

No, I was trying to convince myself it wasn't bad.

This is the only way I can hold myself together.

At least training in martial arts let me drive away the dark thoughts. That was something to be grateful for.

Swish. Ssshk.

I performed the forms of the Jin Family's Spear Technique one after another. Ever since I realized its connection to the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique, my attacks had grown sharper and more precise, sweeping through the empty space before me.

In that empty space, I pictured someone.

Hyuk Mujin.

The first genuine martial artist I had met in this game. A Level 20 powerhouse who had toyed with me like a child.

Could I beat that bastard as I am now?

The instant the question crossed my mind—

Ding.

SYSTEM

A new function, Training Mode, has been activated.
You can summon illusions of opponents you have fought. However, opponents whose Level differs from the user's by ten or more cannot be summoned.
Currently summonable opponents: Lv. 20 Hyuk Mujin, Lv. 10 Heavenly Axe

"Huh?"

Training Mode? I could summon illusions of opponents I had fought before?

After a brief hesitation, I decided to test the new function.

"Summon Hyuk Mujin."

SYSTEM

Summoning Lv. 20 Hyuk Mujin.

The System notification had barely appeared when a transparent figure sprang into existence. He wore the navy martial uniform of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and had Hyuk Mujin's distinctive caterpillar eyebrows. Standing there with his eyes closed, the figure looked exactly like him.

"Holy shit, it's real."

I cautiously approached and touched Hyuk Mujin's body. Perhaps because he was an illusion, my hand passed straight through him.

Good. That passes the safety test.

SYSTEM

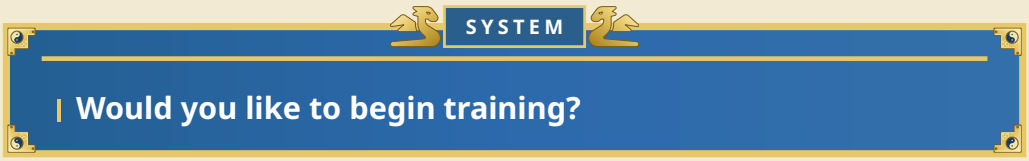
You can partially alter the summoned target's abilities.

"Start him at about half of Hyuk Mujin's strength."

SYSTEM

Entering the data for Lv. 20 Hyuk Mujin. The illusion can use 50% of the original's abilities.

At the same time, Hyuk Mujin's illusion opened his eyes. Maybe it had copied his personality as well as his abilities, because he stared at me with the same insolent look.



“Of course!”

Ding.

The System notification was the starting signal. I charged like lightning and thrust my spear. Even though I was fighting an illusion, I poured out my internal energy without holding back.

First form.

It began with a thrust as I advanced, followed by a twist of the spear shaft. If the enemy failed to evade that first attack, the fight was over.

Ssshwip—

But Hyuk Mujin slipped away like a loach. The next movement immediately became pointless.

Let’s see if you can dodge this too.

I continued unleashing the Spear Technique. The wind screamed as it was torn apart, but Hyuk Mujin dodged every attack.

For an instant, it seemed a sneer crossed his opaque face.

How can you fight so stupidly? A martial artist ought to use martial arts.

Those were the words he had thrown at me while toying with me last time. He was only an illusion I had created, but…

Damn, that pisses me off.

If you’re so confident, stop dodging and come at me.

Hyuk Mujin picked up on my thought and rushed at me in a smooth glide. But this was a fight between a spear and a fist. If I let him land that attack, it would mean I had spent the last seven years digging holes for nothing.

“Where do you think you’re going!”

Whoom—

I swung the spear shaft. If he had been real rather than an illusion, it would have landed with a solid *thwack*. Even if he dodged it, he would fail to close the distance.

Let’s see how far you can dodge.

I launched into the second form. Faced with the torrent of attacks, Hyuk Mujin didn’t dare approach and retreated step by step.

Combat had a flow. I had seized that flow, and Hyuk Mujin was being swept along by it. As I watched him roll across the ground with an exhausted expression, one thought came to mind.

He’s weak.

I could see his movements. The Hyuk Mujin projected here was a fist fighter. By watching his feet, I could tell how he would move and predict what he would do next.

His fists couldn't reach me.

Ssshk-swish-swish!

In a single instant, I thrust three times in succession. It was an attack Jin Taekyung the F-rank Hunter could never have performed.

But Jin Taekyung the Murim martial artist could do it by drawing on his internal energy.

"Kraaagh!"

Hyuk Mujin seemed to scream as the spear pierced his chest.

Without hesitation, I drove it deeper and twisted. The spearhead crushed his breastbone and split his heart. Hyuk Mujin collapsed, his form slowly fading away.

"Ah. This is way too easy."

The fight was over in less than five seconds.

I had held the advantage the entire time, and then it had ended anticlimactically.

Was half strength too weak?

I fell into thought while recovering the internal energy I had depleted by circulating qi.

Hyuk Mujin was Level 20 and a martial artist who had trained in martial arts for at least several years. There was no way he could be this weak.

All right. Again.

I stood with the spear in my hand and closed my eyes, picturing a new Hyuk Mujin.

One hundred eighty centimeters[58] tall. Lean muscles and insolent eyes. I gave him the movements I had seen back then.

When I opened my eyes, an illusion stood before me exactly as I had imagined.

But I wasn't finished yet. Hyuk Mujin needed to be stronger.

Your physical abilities are better than mine.

After I fed in a few more conditions, Hyuk Mujin's illusion smiled pleasantly. He had become much faster and gained stamina that would never run out.

"Yeah. Now you're worth fighting."

Those words were the starting signal.

As Hyuk Mujin charged at me like a streak of light, I thrust my spear.

Ssshk-swish!

[58] One hundred eighty centimeters is about 5 ft 11 in.

Vroooom. Boom!

The spearhead tore through the air. The air burst with the droning of a swarm of bees, whipping up a gust of wind.

It was the ultimate final form of the Jin Family's Spear Technique.

Sky-Piercing Strike.

"Kheugh…"

Hyuk Mujin's illusion looked down at the gaping hole in his chest. Disbelief filled his eyes. Then his knees buckled, and the illusion scattered.

"This isn't right."

As I heard the message announcing that my Mastery of the Jin Family's Spear Technique had increased, I scratched my head.

Why am I still winning?

Had the System made a mistake, or…

Did I just get stronger?

I brushed the thought away as soon as it came to me. That couldn't be it. I wasn't some peerless genius. I had only learned a couple of martial arts.

This isn't going to be much use at this rate.

The whole point was to simulate what would happen if I fought someone strong. What good was it if I kept winning?

If I at least knew which martial arts Hyuk Mujin had learned, I could draw out their power. But wait.

"There's an easier way."

The Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique and the Jin Family's Spear Technique.

What if I gave both of them to the Level 20 Hyuk Mujin?

Seeing them used against me might even let me identify their strengths and weaknesses from an outside perspective.

Yeah. That would be better.

"You think so too, right?"

Hyuk Mujin's illusion had reappeared at some point. It grinned and nodded.

"Then let's fight again."

I raised my spear diagonally and stepped forward with my left foot. Like my reflection in a mirror, the illusion assumed the exact same stance.

"You'll regret this."

"Regret, my ass."

Now I was even talking to an illusion. If anyone saw me, there would be no denying I was a lunatic.

"Crazy bastard."

…It was my own imagination, but it still pissed me off.

“You’re dead.”
Without hesitation, I pointed my spear at him.
Same weapon. Same martial arts.
This looked like it was going to be an interesting fight.
“Interesting? You really are a lunatic.”
Yeah. Fair point.
If I could find this fun in a situation like mine, I had to be pretty damn crazy too.

Chapter 13

The five horses galloped hard. They crossed mountains, fields, and rivers, finally reaching their destination around noon.

“Where have you come from?”

At the tension in the Jin Family of Taiyuan gate guard’s voice, the young man in the lead smiled. His lips curled crookedly, unable to hide the hostility behind them.

“Mount Heng.”

Fifteen minutes later, Jin Wikyung summoned the family’s senior members.

Hyuk Mujin was endlessly versatile. All I had to do was picture him in my mind. Spear, sword, saber, bow… Sometimes I won, and sometimes I lost, but one thing was certain.

“I’ve got the hang of it now.”

The martial arts had become second nature. At first, I had focused on executing them from beginning to end, one form after another. But things were different now.

Forms changed depending on the situation. Martial arts didn’t have to consist of one form flowing into the next in a fixed order. I had reached the point where I could skip the prescribed sequence and link the forms together.

Like this.

Whoooosh!

By the time I heard the wind, it was already too late. Hyuk Mujin, his abdomen pierced through, let out a rueful sigh.

“You’re improving quickly.”

“I spent seven years doing nothing but using a spear, you bastard.”

I closed my eyes. When I opened them again, the empty training hall came into view. As if celebrating my victory, the System notification rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Jin Family's Spear Technique has risen to the Fourth Stage!
Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique has risen to the Fourth Stage!
The forms have become more refined, and their destructive power has increased.
Level up!

"So I'm Level 14 now?"

I had gained three Levels in three days.

That was a steep rise for someone who had spent those three days holed up in the training hall.

On top of that, the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique had reached the Third Stage, while the Manoeuvre Technique and Spear Technique had reached the Fourth Stage.

"Open Status Window."

After distributing my remaining points, my nose prickled with emotion.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 14 Jin Taekyung
Occupation: Second Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 10
Titles: 3 (Title effects active)
Scion of a Prestigious Family: All stats +5, Fame +50
Shame of the Family: All stats –5, Fame –50
Novice Trainee: Training speed +10%
Strength: 51
Stamina: 61
Agility: 61
Intelligence: 10
Charm: 10
Internal Energy: 10 years
Remaining Points: 0

"Beautiful. Just beautiful."

Look at those perfectly balanced stats.

These were stats *of* combat, *by* combat, and *for* combat.

And that's not even counting the martial arts.

I wasn't the same person I had been before. Hyuk Mujin? I was confident I could beat him now.

The F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung, who hadn't known the first thing about martial arts, was dead. I was now a Murim martial artist who had learned a Peak cultivation technique and two first-rate martial arts.

It starts today.

Everything was ready. Once I left the training hall today, I would gather the things I had in mind and leave the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I might even be able to get Jin Wikyung's help.

Just dealing with idiot bandits like the Heavenly Axe would let me reach my target quickly. Two days at most. After that, I could return to the warm embrace of my family.

Mom. Hayeon. I miss you.

My eyes were just beginning to redden when—

Grrrrrr—

"O-oh! Ohhh!"

This was the moment I had been waiting for. The iron door blocking the entrance to the training hall was opening. That ugly, heavy chunk of metal looked as beautiful as the gates of heaven.

"Finally! I'm getting out!"

My face alight with joy, I ran toward the entrance to heaven.

The angel who would free me from this place appeared from behind the door.

"Third Young Master. It's been three days."

He wasn't exactly a welcome sight, but I was too happy to care.

"You came to let me out, right? Huh? You did, right?"

Wipeng, an angel who resembled a desert fox, answered in a strangely qualified tone.

"Yes. For now."

"…What?"

"You will be leaving. But there's somewhere we need to stop by first."

"Somewhere we need to stop by?"

A chill ran down my spine. My survival instincts kicked in.

"Where are we going?"

"The main assembly hall. The Lesser Family Head is waiting there as well. And…"

Wipeng added,

"Senior members of our family and an envoy from the Mount Heng Sword Sect have also arrived."

"The Mount Heng Sword Sect? Why the hell are they here?"

Wolhwa had told me at Honghwaru that the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect were sworn enemies. So why were those bastards here?

Things are going wrong.

This was ominous. Very ominous. I had to find some way out of this.

“Then could I stop by my residence and change clothes first?”

“No.”

“It seems like an important occasion, and I can’t show up smelling like this…”

“Are you thinking of running away?”

He looked like a desert fox, but his instincts put a meerkat to shame. Before I could say anything, Wipeng’s hand pressed down hard on my shoulder.

“Third Young Master. From now on, answer my questions truthfully. Understood?”

His voice was dry, and his eyes were cold. The aura coming from him left me unable to speak. All I could do was nod.

Jin Taekyung.

The three-syllable name flashed through my mind.

There was no doubt about it. This bastard was responsible. He had dumped a load of shit without me even knowing.

And then…

“Is it true that you tried to violate a woman of the Mount Heng Sword Sect?”

That shit was far bigger than I could have imagined.

As I followed Wipeng toward the main assembly hall, my mind went completely blank.

Attempted sexual assault?

Even if it had only been an attempt, it was a sex crime so vile that beating the culprit to death wouldn’t have been enough.

I remembered how I had always said that, as a human being and an older brother with a younger sister, sex offenders should be executed.

That crazy son of a bitch.

My palms were slick with cold sweat. I said it again, no longer knowing how many times I had repeated myself.

“I really wasn’t the one. Please believe me.”

Without turning around, Wipeng replied,

“Has your memory returned?”

“No, that’s not what I mean. I’m telling you, it really wasn’t me. Do I look like the kind of guy who’d do that? The kind of guy who’d go around committing trash like that?”

"Yes."

No, fuck.

He answered without even taking a breath.

"Look, then let me stop by the bathroom. Or the privy, I mean."

"No."

"You have to let me take care of business!"

"Just go where you are."

Son of a bitch. I gave up and immediately spun around and ran, drawing up all my internal energy and concentrating it in my feet.

A hand clamped around the back of my neck.

"Third Young Master."

I had been caught in three steps. Wipeng looked down at me with cold eyes.

"If you keep this up… I might have to stop being polite."

Resistance was pointless. Wipeng was a master whose Level I couldn't determine even with Qi Sense.

No choice.

I walked on with a sinking heart. After what felt like ages, a towering pavilion came into view.

Several warriors stood guard outside. I recognized the Jin Family of Taiyuan's distinctive navy uniforms, but some of the men wore red clothes I had never seen before.

Those must be members of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Considering the usual relationship between the two sects, they should have been at each other's throats. Yet right now, they were united in glaring at me.

"Fuck…"

Wipeng turned his head at my mutter.

"The Lesser Family Head believes in you. Don't forget that."

Right. Jin Wikyung was there. My greatest hope and my shield.

As I reminded myself of that fact, Wipeng threw open the doors to the main assembly hall.

"I've brought the Third Young Master."

I took a deep breath and stepped into the pavilion, repeating the same words over and over in my head.

Even if a tiger carries you off, you can survive if you keep your wits about you. Even if a tiger carries you off, you can keep your wits—

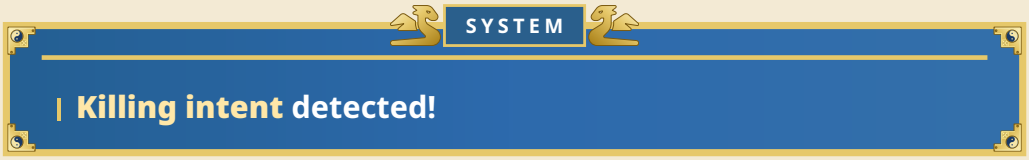
The moment I entered the hall, the low murmuring abruptly stopped. A dozen men, young and old, stood arrayed along either side, while Jin Wikyung occupied the seat of honor.

And in the center stood a young man.

“It’s been a while, Young Master Jin.”

The instant I met that unpleasant smile—

Ding.



…At least use your blinker before cutting in.

Killing intent.

I knew it well. Monsters were literally bundles of malice and killing intent. I had felt it countless times and thought I had grown used to it.

But this guy…

He was different.

This was on an entirely different level from anything I had experienced.

If I had to compare it to something, it was like the difference between a low-level monster and a mid-level monster. His killing intent was far more refined, more furtive, and more chilling.

“I believe I caught a glimpse of you in the marketplace last time. I don’t know whether you remember me.”

Lee Seogeun bit off each word. Above his head, a System window floated in the air.

That was the Level I had seen with Qi Sense the instant I detected his killing intent. It was more than twice my Level.

This is insane.

Even worse were the looks from everyone else.

Dozens of menacing gazes from men young and old were fixed on me. My knees went weak. In that tense atmosphere, Lee Seogeun spoke again.

“What a shame. If you had come a little earlier, we could have had a deeper conversation. We were discussing something interesting until just now.”

“…Were you?”

“Wouldn’t you like to know what we were discussing?”

“N-no, I’m fine.”

I only hoped it hadn't been a discussion about whether to cut off my head or my balls. And if that miserable guess was correct, I would rather they cut off my balls than my head.

If I'm lucky, a Level Up might restore them… Why am I even having to think about this?

This was beyond grim. Lee Seogeun studied my expression for a moment before speaking again.

"I heard you returned to the family a few days ago. Where have you been?"

"Honghwaru."

"Then where were you before you went to Honghwaru?"

I was at a goshiwon[59], you bastard.

I wanted to tell him everything honestly.

I got fired from my Guild that day, had some soju[60] with the hyung[61] from my goshiwon[62], then climbed into the capsule and fell asleep. When I woke up, I was at Honghwaru, and now I'm working hard so I can Logout. Something like that.

It'd be a miracle if he didn't draw his sword.

As I hesitated, unable to answer, Lee Seogeun pulled something from inside his robes. I thought he really was drawing a sword, but it turned out to be a bundle of papers.

"Since you don't seem to remember, I'll tell you. The night before you went to Honghwaru, you visited Myeongwollu. You went to the deluxe room you had reserved."

"Myeongwollu?"

"Isn't that the pleasure house you used to frequent? Don't try to claim you've never heard of it. I have the statements and signatures of the people who saw you there that day."

In other words, it was a list of witness statements. I read through the papers, figuring I might as well see what they said.

Then I noticed something strange.

"What is this?"

"You don't know even after seeing it yourself?"

This bastard was dropping the formal speech now, too.

"I'm saying that because I read it. There isn't a single proper testimony here."

---

[59] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, originally intended for people studying for exams.

[60] *Soju* is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

[61] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[62] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, originally intended for people studying for exams.

I read every one of the dozens of statements, but not one of them contained decisive testimony.

They all said roughly the same thing: Jin Taekyung had gotten thoroughly drunk, gone to the wrong room, and found that the room belonged to a woman of the Mount Heng Sword Sect. Then someone had heard screaming.

“For a bastard who tore my sister’s clothes and tried to rape her, you have some nerve acting so shameless. You really are exactly as the rumors say.”

“No, that’s not what—”

“You bastard!”

Flutter!

“Ah.”

The bundle of papers smacked me in the face and scattered across the floor. Lee Seogeun spat a glob of phlegm onto them.

Well, look at this asshole.

I wasn’t annoyed. I was simply suspicious.

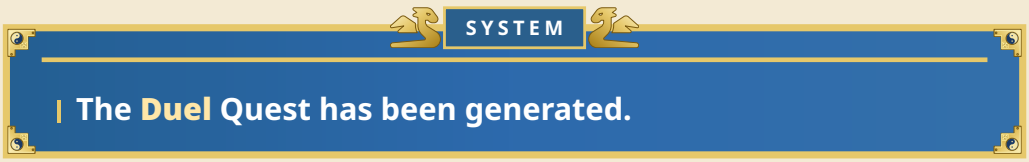
How should I put it? This whole chain of events—especially the witness statements—felt incredibly contrived.

But I had no time to dwell on that unease.

“Come out with me, you bastard! I’ll make you pay for what you’ve done!”

The instant Lee Seogeun shouted—

Ding.



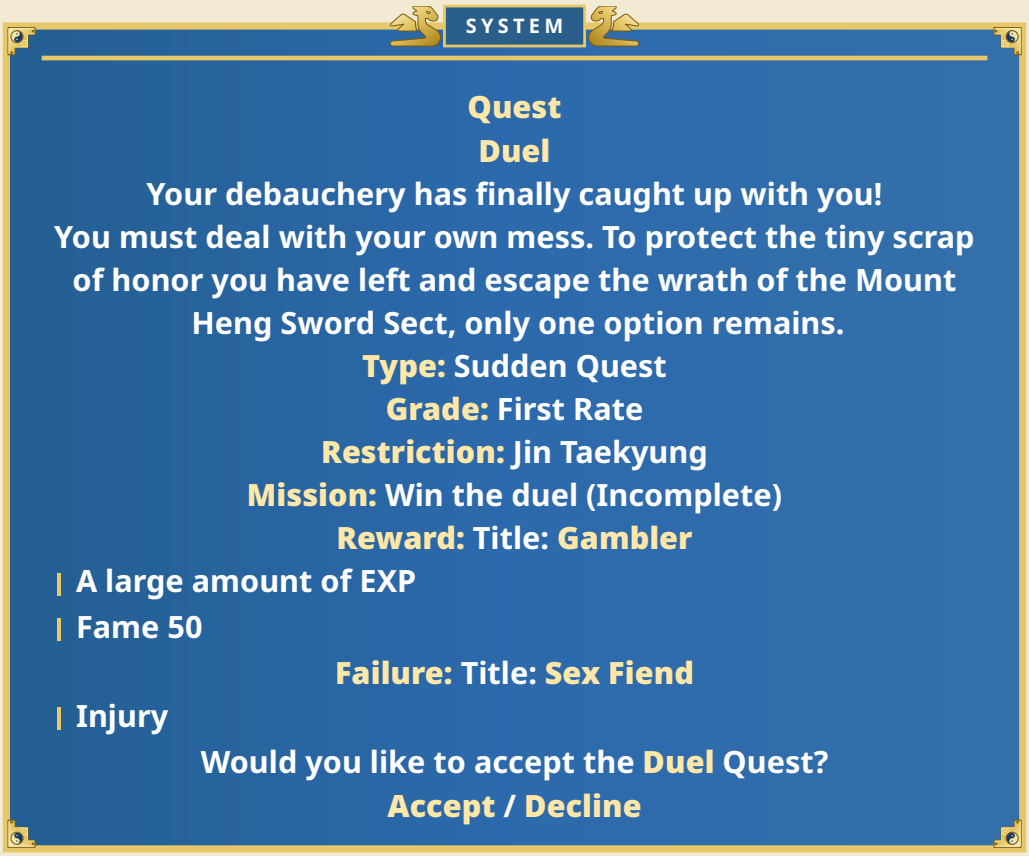
What’s this now?

Chapter 14

“Come out with me, you bastard! I’ll make you pay for what you’ve done!”

The instant Lee Seogeun shouted those words in fury—

Ding.



“…”

Seriously? I hadn’t even dated anyone since high school, and now I had to be called a sex fiend?

I spent half my day running raids and the other half passed out in my goshiwon[63]. Now I had to clean up a mess I hadn’t even made, inside a game.

At least give me a decent Quest.

How was I supposed to fight a Level 30 like Lee Seogeun?

This is insane. His Level is more than twice mine…

This was a fight I absolutely couldn’t take.

I declined the Quest. Or I was going to. But Lee Seogeun beat me to it.

“If you run away from this place… the Jin Family of Taiyuan will pay the appropriate price.”

Ding.

[63] A goshiwon is a low-cost residence in Korea made up of very small private rooms, originally associated with students preparing for exams.

SYSTEM

Quest information has been updated.

If the Quest is declined, the Mount Heng Sword Sect will declare war on the Jin Family of Taiyuan. In addition, Jin Taekyung will be designated a public enemy of the sect.

…I knew it.

I'd wondered why the System was giving me a choice for once.

As I let out a deep sigh, the assembly hall began boiling like a cauldron over hot coals.

"How dare you!"

"That young punk thinks he can say whatever he wants just because he has his family behind him!"

"Even if the Third Young Master did something lower than a dog, how dare he look down on our family!"

"…"

The first two were fine, but who the hell was that last guy?

As the atmosphere turned hostile, Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head, stepped in.

"Everyone, calm yourselves. And you, Young Hero, that is enough. We will consider it a slip of the tongue and let it pass this once."

Seated in the place of honor, he delivered the warning in a low voice. His presence was no joke. He truly had the bearing of the next Family Head of an old and prestigious house.

Perhaps cowed by his aura, Lee Seogeun answered in a noticeably quieter voice.

"Understood. However…"

"However?"

"It was not a slip of the tongue. Do you think I came here today merely as a private individual?"

At those words, Jin Wikyung's expression hardened, along with everyone else's.

Right. Lee Seogeun was an official envoy of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

"My father—no, the Sect Leader—has entrusted me with full authority."

"…Then what do you want?"

"As I have already said, I want a duel with the Third Young Master."

No. I don't want that.

Judging by how things were unfolding, those bastards from the Mount Heng Sword Sect had come here specifically to pick a fight.

They intended to squeeze everything they could out of this incident, and even if that failed, they were at least going to wreck me. Being targeted so blatantly sent a chill down my spine.

"There must be another way. Tell me what you truly want."

"Withdraw from every commandery and county outside Taiyuan. That should be an appropriate price for ruining my sister's prospects of marriage."

The instant he finished speaking, shouts erupted throughout the assembly hall.

From the bits and pieces I could make out, he was basically demanding they strip us of everything but our underwear. Jin Wikyung's answer was obvious.

"Impossible."

"Then accept the duel—"

"That too, I must refuse."

Jin Wikyung was a complete pushover when it came to his youngest brother. There was no way he would send me into a duel that was obviously dangerous.

At Jin Wikyung's answer, Lee Seogeun smiled triumphantly.

"Then there is only one path left."

War.

I wasn't the only one who thought of that word. The assembly hall fell silent beneath its weight.

Amid that silence, I looked up at the empty air.

SYSTEM

Would you like to accept the Quest?
Accept / Decline
If the Quest is declined, the Mount Heng Sword Sect will declare war on the Jin Family of Taiyuan. In addition, Jin Taekyung will be designated a public enemy of the sect.

I read the System message, looked at the floor, looked at the ceiling, then read it again.

Fuck…

There was no choice. Only one way remained.

"I'll do it."

For once, everyone reacted the same way. Eyes wide. Mouths open. Lee Seogeun, who had proposed the duel. Jin Wikyung, who had refused it. Everyone in the assembly hall looked as though they couldn't believe their ears.

"W-wait. Taekyung?"

Ignoring Jin Wikyung's frantic attempt to stop me, I spoke to Lee Seogeun.

"Come out. Let's have a go."

The corners of Lee Seogeun's mouth curled into a cruel smile.

The winter wind was cold. I looked up at the cloudy sky and took a deep breath.

"Whoo."

Lee Seogeun and I stood facing each other in the Jin Family of Taiyuan's Grand Training Ground. About fifty people sat some distance away, watching us.

The Jin Family people looked like they were wondering what the hell I had eaten, while the Mount Heng Sword Sect's goons looked like they'd come out for a day of entertainment. All they were missing was popcorn.

Ah. Someone was sending me a Sound Transmission, too.

"Youngest. Take deep breaths. Deep breaths. In. Out. In. Out…"

I'm already doing that, man.

Jin Wikyung had a solemn expression, but he kept shifting his hips like a puppy that needed to poop. If Wipeng hadn't been holding him down by the shoulder, he looked ready to charge into the training ground at any moment.

"Don't worry. If it looks dangerous, this eldest brother of yours will jump in. What? If that bastard so much as lays a hand on our youngest brother, I'll—fuck! Got it? Don't get worked up. Take it slow and stay safe. You can do it, Jin Taekyung!"

…I get it, so calm down.

He had radiated such overwhelming authority in the assembly hall, yet Jin Wikyung was once again living up to my expectations.

Still, he's a hundred times better than having no one.

At least someone would save me before I became a half-crippled wreck.

With Jin Wikyung and Wipeng, I had two life insurance policies. Great.

But the moment I looked at Lee Seogeun with a slightly lighter heart, I immediately took that thought back.

What's so great about this? Fuck.

Now I understood why the Mount Heng Sword Sect's people had been so confident.

Lee Seogeun abruptly whipped off his shirt, and my breath caught at the sight of muscles writhing like mollusks.

My hands and feet began to tingle at the sight of the blood-red Level window.

A gap of sixteen Levels. It was overwhelming. As if to drive that fact home, the System chimed.

SYSTEM

You have been afflicted with the Status Effect Intimidation!

I'll die three times before anyone gets here to save me.

Perhaps he noticed my reaction, because Lee Seogeun gave me a cruel smile.

"Do you understand the situation now? Your breath catches, and your hands and feet start tingling, don't they?"

Now he could read minds, too?

But momentum was half the fight.

I deliberately composed my expression before answering.

"Bullshit."

"Your voice is trembling. Of course you're afraid. Fine. Answer my questions honestly, and I'll go easy on you."

...To be honest, I almost wavered.

"Cut the bullshit."

"Oh? Putting on the airs of a martial family's son, are you?"

Lee Seogeun laughed scornfully.

"Let me ask you one thing. What made you accept the duel? Your martial arts are pathetic, and you're notorious for being a coward. I want to hear your reason."

"The reason?"

No matter how much I thought about it, this was the only way.

If war broke out, I would become a public enemy of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Hunting? Leveling up? I could forget about it. The moment I stepped outside the protection of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, assassins would catch my scent and come running.

As long as I stay alive, there'll be another chance.

I had magic. The recovery magic of leveling up.

My mind eased slightly.

"I figured I could handle someone like you."

"Pfft! You're just a wet-behind-the-ears pup."

It was a mild provocation, but it didn't work. He was confident in his own abilities, and it showed in his relaxed manner.

"Is it my turn to ask a question?"

"I never said I would answer... but I'll indulge you as if these were your last words."

"This whole incident. You fabricated it, didn't you?"

Perhaps the question caught him off guard, because Lee Seogeun's face stiffened awkwardly.

That expression was answer enough.

So I was right.

I'd suspected as much. No wonder the whole thing had stunk from beginning to end.

"You petty bastards. You should've just declared war."

"…I'll tear that mouth apart."

Lee Seogeun raised his massive greatsword and muttered ominously.

I raised the Sharp Spear I had drawn earlier.

All right. Let's do this.

I had learned martial arts. I also had instincts honed through seven years of real combat.

An F-rank Hunter and a second-rate Murim martial artist. Don't underestimate the skills I'd honed working two jobs!

"Graaah!"

Lee Seogeun was more agile than I had imagined. He closed the distance in an instant, and I caught the greatsword crashing straight down with the shaft of my spear.

Kra-kra-kraang.

"Urgh."

I'd been afraid it might cut me in half, but the Sharp Spear was sturdy, made of solid steel. Even so, the force behind the greatsword began driving both my feet into the ground.

"Die, you insect!"

"Hup!"

Up close, his aura was even more suffocating. Was this what a monster's Fear felt like?

"Kneel and beg forgiveness now! Then I'll let you off with just one arm!"

"Youngest!"

Over Lee Seogeun's shoulder, I saw Jin Wikyung shoot to his feet. The Mount Heng Sword Sect's people watched with snickers, while the Jin Family people turned their heads away as if they couldn't bear to look.

I have to hold out.

At least until Jin Wikyung gets here!

"Graaah!"

Lee Seogeun's greatsword came at me from every direction, one blow after another. The weapons were clearly clashing, iron against iron, but all I could hear was cannon fire.

Boom! Boom! Boom! I blocked them.

“Graaah!”

“Hup!”

Boom! Boom! I blocked them again.

“Graaah!”

“Haaah!”

Boom! I blocked another.

“Graaah…”

“Haaah…”

“…?”

“…?”

The next moment, Lee Seogeun and I locked eyes.

The instant I saw the bewilderment and confusion in his gaze, I knew he was thinking exactly what I was.

What the hell is this?

Lee Seogeun was strong. He possessed the brute strength of a giant monster, moved with surprising agility for someone so muscular, and swung his massive greatsword like a matchstick.

And that wasn’t all. He was a Young Master of the Mount Heng Sword Sect—a sect that could actually throw its weight around. The martial arts he used had to be quite advanced.

And yet…

This is… doable?

Even now, I was blocking every swing of his greatsword. More than twenty attacks, and more than twenty blocks.

I could see them. That was why I could block them.

I cautiously lifted one of my legs, which had sunk into the ground up to the ankle. It slid right out.

Could it be…

No way. Surely not.

Ssshwip!

At that moment, a greatsword swept toward my waist. I deflected it with the shaft of my spear, then reflexively kicked Lee Seogeun in his wide-open chest.

Whack!

“Urgh!”

…Huh?

Clutching his stomach, Lee Seogeun skidded back five or six steps. Then he casually rubbed the bridge of his nose as though nothing had happened.

“You’re not bad. For trash, you have a trick or two.”

“…”

“Heh. But I’m done going easy on you.”

“…Hey.”

“With my next strike, I’ll smash your head—what?”

With a queasy look, I raised a hand and pointed at his mouth.

“You’re bleeding.”

A beat later, a thin line of blood ran down from the corner of Lee Seogeun’s mouth. He had probably bitten his tongue. That had to hurt.

“Ah! Eeng! Eek! Hup!”

Lee Seogeun wiped away the blood with a series of ridiculous yelps.

“Don’t wipe it. Leave it.”

“…?”

“It’ll be easier to wipe it all off at once later.”

Because from now on, I was going to beat the absolute shit out of him.

SYSTEM

The Status Effect **Intimidation** has been removed!

Chapter 15

Wipeng thought,

What am I looking at?

Something unbelievable was happening before his eyes. The Third Young Master—of all people, that very Third Young Master—was holding his own against Lee Seogeun.

Am I hallucinating?

And who was Lee Seogeun?

He was a blood relative of the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, heir to his martial arts, and a first-rate swordsman.

When the Third Young Master first accepted Lee Seogeun's challenge to a duel, Wipeng had sighed inwardly. *What kind of nerve did someone who had barely risen above third-rate think he had?*

And then what? *Come out? Let's have a go?*

Crazy bastard. What a load of shit.

Something did seem to have changed about him lately. He had suddenly started speaking politely to everyone. He practiced martial arts until late at night.

Oh, and there was that bullshit about losing his memory.

At the time, Wipeng had wondered if the man had gone insane. But when he heard today that the Third Young Master had laid a hand on the Mount Heng Sword Sect's cherished jewel, everything became clear. The shock had nearly sent him straight to the heavens.

Of course. No one changes overnight.

Wipeng had served the Jin Family of Taiyuan for more than ten years. In his eyes, Jin Taekyung was far beyond a bad seed with yellow sprouts—his were practically gold.[64]

But what could he do? Taekyung was his lord's beloved youngest brother and a direct-line member of the Jin Family. Wipeng had been planning to rescue him before Lee Seogeun turned him into a half-cripple.

And yet…

Whack! Whack! Whack!

Now Taekyung was beating Lee Seogeun without mercy.

Wipeng knew the martial arts he was using: the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique and Spear Technique.

[64] *Ssaksuga norata*—"the sprouts are yellow"—means someone shows no promise. Wipeng exaggerates the yellow to gold.

He was fairly skilled at linking the two techniques together, and there was even a seasoned air to his movements—the hard-won experience of a wandering martial artist who had spent around ten years roughing it in back alleys.

What in the world…?

No one could master martial arts in a day or two.

That was the natural order Wipeng believed in, and he knew exactly one person who defied it.

The Second Young Master.

Jin Mukyung, the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. A genius who had reached the Peak realm before the age of twenty—a true prodigy who defied the natural order.

Could the Third Young Master possibly…?

Wipeng's thoughts went no further. A commotion had broken out around them.

"This duel is invalid!"

"Stop the duel immediately!"

"The Jin Family of Taiyuan used underhanded tricks!"

"That's right! Otherwise, how could our Young Master possibly lose to trash like that—"

The Mount Heng Sword Sect warriors who had been snickering moments ago now had their hands on their sword hilts.

Look at these lunatics.

It was true that the Mount Heng Sword Sect had been riding high lately, but for even its underlings to cause such a scene—

Just as Wipeng could bear it no longer and was about to step forward—

Whoosh—smack!

The wind blew, and more than ten teeth flew through the air.

A Mount Heng Sword Sect warrior, blood pouring from the corner of his mouth, stared blankly up at the enormous shadow looming over him.

"What trash?"

"Buh… buh-buh…"

Jin Wikyung calmly looked down at the warrior, who could no longer form the words. Then he slapped the man across the mouth with a palm as large as a cauldron lid.

Smack! Clatter.

The warrior spat out every tooth he had left, then lost consciousness and collapsed.

Leaving the frozen Mount Heng Sword Sect warriors behind, Jin Wikyung returned to his seat and resumed watching the duel.

Wipeng sighed.

"There could be a problem…"

"Wipeng."

"Yes?"

"Don't say anything."

Jin Wikyung gazed at his youngest brother with shining eyes and added,

"This is the best moment of my life."

This was my first time using martial arts in actual combat. Since learning them, I hadn't had any reason to fight anyone—and I hadn't wanted to, either.

But…

I had always thought about it. If I ever encountered an enemy, if the moment came when I had to use my martial arts in a real fight, how would I respond?

In that respect, my time in the training hall had meant a great deal.

Whack!

"Guh!"

Lee Seogeun doubled over like a shrimp as the shaft of my spear struck him squarely in the abdomen.

He had dropped his greatsword long ago. I kept advancing and swinging the shaft, and each blow tore another scream from him.

Whack! Whack! Whack!

"Gaaaah!"

At first, I had been bewildered. *My kick actually worked? On Lee Seogeun? He's Level 30, and I'm only Level 14.*

But after we exchanged more than fifty blows, I realized the truth.

I'm stronger.

Lee Seogeun was undoubtedly strong. By real-world standards, he was at least on par with a C-rank Hunter.

But I was stronger. The difference was slight, but undeniable.

Strength, Stamina, Agility.

And experience.

"Graaah!"

Lee Seogeun charged at me with a roar. He was fast. And destructive. Every step he took left the training-ground floor dented and cracked.

But he has no finesse.

Lee Seogeun was young, which meant he lacked experience. Against someone weaker, he could make up for that with sheer strength.

But I was different.

I was stronger, and I had more experience.

I'm going to win. Without a doubt.

It wasn't a resolution. It was certainty.

That was why I discarded my spear without hesitation. Now we were both unarmed.

The moment Lee Seogeun saw me throw away my weapon, fire blazed in his eyes.

"You looked down on me? You dare—how dare you!"

Anger stiffened the body and simplified its movements. I tripped Lee Seogeun's leg as he charged like a bull and sent him tumbling.

Then I climbed onto his chest as he tried to get up.

"What is this…?"

Looking down at his bewildered eyes, I asked,

"Ever heard of full mount?"

Without waiting for an answer, I drove my fist down.

Lee Seogeun desperately shook his head from side to side, but it did him no good.

Bam-bam-bam-bam!

Chin, cheek, forehead, nose… I rained punches down across his entire face. Lee Seogeun twisted and screamed without end until, at last, he went limp.

That should be enough.

My whole reason for accepting the duel had been to avoid a war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

It would be a problem if Lee Seogeun suffered a severe injury. I had to stop before I went too far.

Concerned, I shook Lee Seogeun by the shoulder.

"Hey, are you oka—"

Smack!

The world flashed before my eyes.

A little dizziness. Drops of bright-red blood dripped from my stinging chin.

Lee Seogeun's fist had grazed me.

Ah. I let my guard down.

If I hadn't instinctively jerked my head back, I would have been in serious trouble. That blow had been imbued with internal energy.

"You dodged that?"

Lee Seogeun quickly broke free of the mount and scrambled away, his face filled with extreme bewilderment.

Of course. He probably hadn't imagined that a guy like me—no, a guy like Jin Taekyung—would humiliate him like this.

Especially after his decisive strike had been rendered useless.

“This can’t be… This can’t be happening.”

I answered Lee Seogeun, who muttered as if he were bewitched.

“Life’s full of surprises.”

“Why? How? How could this possibly happen? I’m Lee Seogeun! Lee Seogeun of the Mount Heng Sword Sect!”

His eyes bloodshot, Lee Seogeun shouted,

“I honed my skills for ten years! So why? Why am I losing to trash like you? To someone as debauched and lazy as you!”

He might have been nothing more than a game character, but in that moment, I understood how he felt.

The feeling that all his hard work had betrayed him. The futility. The emptiness.

I felt that way, too.

I had felt it for seven years. The sense of deprivation dulled with time, but it never disappeared.

In the end, I had accepted it.

Reality was cruel.

I spoke to Lee Seogeun.

“Give up now. You’re weaker than me.”

Lee Seogeun’s eyes rolled with rage.

“Shut your mouth!”

The air around us crackled.

Gathering every last bit of strength he had, Lee Seogeun shot forward like an arrow.

“I told you clearly. You made your choice.”

“Stop spouting bullshit!”

Whoosh.

His fist split the air and grazed my face by a hair. That alone sliced open my skin and drew blood.

It was faster and stronger than any attack I had seen from him so far.

But the same goes for me.

I channeled internal energy into my right foot and brought it down on top of Lee Seogeun’s foot.

Crack!

With the sound of breaking bone, his foot slammed into the training-ground floor and sank into it.

“Graaah!”

I drove my knuckles into his screaming face. His nose broke, and teeth scattered through the air. With his leg buried up to the calf, he couldn't even pull himself free.

One more.

More.

More.

Whack. Whack. Whack.

Chest. Side. Stomach.

And finally—

The solar plexus.

Thump!

A clean hit.

And it wasn't just an ordinary punch. I had concentrated a tremendous amount of internal energy into that single blow.

Lee Seogeun's eyes flew wide.

"Guh!"

His pupils lost focus. The strength left his body, his back bent, and he began to collapse.

I saw it all as if in slow motion.

Even my right foot shooting toward his abdomen.

Pop!

With a sound like a balloon bursting, Lee Seogeun went flying.

Everyone watched.

Jin Wikyung. Wipeng. The people of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. The warriors of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

And me.

Thud.

Lee Seogeun flew more than ten meters[65] before landing. Whether he had passed out or not, he did not move.

I released the breath I had been holding and stood tall beneath the dozens of gazes that shifted from Lee Seogeun to me.

"Whoo… Whoo…"

Ding.

[65] More than ten meters is more than about 33 ft.

SYSTEM

The Duel Quest has been successfully completed!
Quest rewards will be distributed!
You have acquired the Title Gambler!
You have gained EXP and Fame!
An additional reward has been granted for your overwhelming performance!
Jin Family's Cultivation Technique has risen to the Fourth Stage!
Qi Sense has risen to the Third Stage. You can now identify targets up to Level 50.
Level up!
Level up!
Level up!

The System notifications rang out like celebratory fireworks.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect left.

Since they had all arrived on horseback, the Jin Family of Taiyuan even had to lend them a carriage to transport the injured.

But Lee Seogeun was one thing. Who was the other guy?

Every tooth in his mouth was gone, and the cloth stuffed between his lips was soaked with blood.

Good Lord. What kind of bastard had…?

Jin Wikyung patted me on the shoulder with a solemn expression.

"Well done. You surpassed my expectations."

"Ah, yes. Thank you—"

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

Because there's blood splattered on your cheek.

I had no idea why, but in that brief span of time, he had somehow turned someone into a cripple.

"So, what do you think?"

"Pardon? About what?"

"About ending your confinement. It is true that your usual conduct has been disgraceful, but after the remarkable performance you showed today, this is a great blessing for our family."

Jin Wikyung looked around as he continued.

"What do the rest of you think?"

The senior members looked displeased, but none seemed particularly inclined to object. Compared to the looks they had given me in the meeting hall earlier, I almost felt that they were favorable.

Is it because they're Murim people?

In the novels, Murim was a place where justice mattered, but strength came first. Maybe defeating Lee Seogeun had influenced them.

"You should answer him. Hahaha."

…Or maybe it was because of Jin Wikyung.

His mouth was smiling, but his eyes were not. With the blood on his cheek, he looked like something out of a horror movie.

"I wholeheartedly agree."

Once Wipeng's manipulation of public opinion was added to the mix, one by one, the others voiced their agreement.

Jin Wikyung watched the blatantly rigged vote unfold under threat of force and smiled in satisfaction.

Damn it. Damn it. Damn it!

Lee Seogeun bit down hard on his lip. Jin Taekyung's face refused to leave his mind.

I lost? To trash like him?

The matter with the Jin Family of Taiyuan had provided more than enough justification.

If the Mount Heng Sword Sect gained something from it, that was good. If the Jin Family refused their demands and the conflict escalated into a full-scale war, that would have been a success as well.

If he had turned Jin Taekyung into a half-cripple, word would have spread throughout Shanxi Province that the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been humiliated by the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

But he had failed.

How could this have happened?

He had taken up the sword as a child. He wasn't a genius, but neither was he ordinary.

The second son of the Mount Heng Sword Sect. A promising young prodigy. A first-rate swordsman.

He had always been an object of admiration…

Damn it!

Everything he had was shattered today. For the first time, Jin Taekyung's merciless violence had brought him to his knees and beaten him unconscious.

When he opened his eyes, he was already inside a carriage.

Even the carriage belonged to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Fire blazed in Lee Seogeun's eyes.

I'll kill you. I'll kill you with my own hands, Jin Taekyung!

Unable to contain his mounting fury, he slammed his fist against the carriage wall.

The carriage stopped.

Lee Seogeun shouted harshly,

"What are you doing? Don't dawdle. Get moving again!"

At that moment, his brow prickled.

"We should get moving, yes. But going to the Mount Heng Sword Sect would be a little troublesome."

Sound Transmission?

Who are you?

Lee Seogeun shouted, but no sound escaped his throat.

His chest felt tight, and his throat hurt as if it were on fire. The carriage began moving again.

"Let's do this. Mount Beimang first. We can go to the Mount Heng Sword Sect afterward."[66]

What does that mean—

It took no longer than a few blinks.

His limbs went numb, and pain flared violently through his body. Lee Seogeun turned his trembling head.

Someone in a mask was staring at him.

"Grrk… grrrk…"

Who are you?

Instead of a voice, dark, discolored blood poured from his mouth.

His vision blurred. The sounds around him faded into the distance.

Sa… save me…

That was his final thought.

The next moment, he plunged headfirst into darkness.

"Farewell, Young Hero."

The masked man smiled as he pulled the large blue-black needle from the dead man's brow.

[66] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds; "going to Beimang" means dying.

Chapter 16

"Whew. Finally done."

Jin Wikyung set down his brush as he spoke. Wipeng, who was sitting in a chair beside the door as always, raised his head.

"You're getting faster at handling your work. You must be exhausted toda—"

Wipeng trailed off when he noticed the mountain of documents still piled on the table.

Come to think of it, it was only around noon. There was no way anyone could have finished that much work already.

Did I hear him wrong?

"Good. This should be enough…"

This time, it wasn't a hallucination. Jin Wikyung's face popped up above the pile of documents, proving it.

"Wipeng, come here. This is very important."

His voice was so serious that Wipeng grew slightly concerned.

Did something major happen?

Perhaps the documents had revealed some grave corruption. Or maybe the Council of Elders, ever watchful for an opportunity, had caused some kind of incident.

This is bad. We haven't even finished dealing with the Mount Heng Sword Sect yet.

A moment later, Wipeng accepted the document in question from Jin Wikyung. His face twisted into a strange expression.

"…What is this?"

"You can't tell? It's a drawing."

The troubling document Wipeng had imagined was nowhere to be seen. Instead, Jin Wikyung had handed him a single sheet of rice paper bearing a drawing.

"No, that's not what I meant. Why are you suddenly—"

Jin Wikyung cut him off with a secretive smile.

"Look closely. It isn't an ordinary drawing."

It isn't an ordinary drawing?

Wipeng's eyes lit up.

All kinds of legends from across Murim flashed through his mind.

A Daoist[67] who ascended after gazing upon a single painting. An absolute master who attained enlightenment from a mural in an ancient cave!

Wipeng's gaze roamed across the rice paper for a long while. Then it suddenly began to tremble as if struck by lightning.

[67] A Daoist is a practitioner of Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition.

“C-could this be…?”

“You noticed. That’s right.”

Jin Wikyung chuckled.

“I drew yesterday’s duel.”

“…”

“Lee Seogeun lying defeated, and Taekyung standing proudly! The sky spread above the head of the young hero who would one day become the greatest under heaven!”

“…”

“I deliberately drew it from a low angle. What do you think? It’s good, right? Isn’t it?”

Wipeng’s hands trembled around the rice paper. If he had followed his heart, he would have crumpled it up, torn it apart, covered it with a week’s worth of piss and shit, dried it thoroughly, and then burned it.

But—

“…It’s very well drawn.”

Wipeng was a rational man. He summoned the magnificent mental fortitude of a martial artist at the Peak realm.

Of course, he also had the courage to reprimand a lord whose sanity was in serious doubt.

“With all the work you have piled up, how could you spend the entire morning drawing this one picture?”

“Of course not.”

“You know that, and yet—”

“Did you think I spent three shichen[68] working on only one?”

“What?”

“Of course I drew another. I was going to show it to you later, but you really are quick on the uptake.”

With trembling hands, Wipeng accepted the second sheet of rice paper Jin Wikyung offered him. Grinning from ear to ear, Jin Wikyung began explaining the drawing.

“I depicted the scene immediately after the duel. The young hero declares that he won’t rest on his laurels and will return to the training hall! And the people gazing up at him in admiration!”

“Well, I agree with much of that. The Third Young Master really has changed a great deal.”

“Right? I was surprised myself.”

[68] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; three shichen are about six hours.

After defeating Lee Seogeun in the duel, Jin Taekyung had defied everyone's expectations and returned to the training hall. Jin Wikyung's eyes grew distant as he recalled the previous day.

"I always knew this day would come. My youngest brother is a Heavenly Eagle. Wipeng, can't you hear it? The mighty beating of Taekyung's wings…"

"I don't know about wings, but I can hear you spouting nonsense."

Wipeng lowered the rice paper with a sigh of complete resignation.

Flap.

"Gasp."

"See? You can hear it!"

Wipeng hurriedly turned toward the window. A hawk that had just landed was preening its feathers. A small container hung from its ankle.

"It's a messenger eagle."

These hawks were trained intensively from the time they were fledglings before being put to use as messengers.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had only two messenger eagles, and they were dispatched solely for matters of extreme urgency.

"We have a problem."

Jin Wikyung muttered in a subdued voice.

And that problem soon made itself known.

"My name is Han Yeop."

"Pardon?"

"It's an honor to meet you."

The introduction came out of nowhere. Of course, I recognized his face.

I had seen him more often than anyone else since entering the training hall.

Should I call him the training hall guard?

Guard. Martial-artist guard. Whatever the proper term was, the NPC in front of me was a Jin Family of Taiyuan martial artist assigned to the training hall. Bringing me meals and herbal decoctions was one of his duties, too.

But why is he introducing himself all of a sudden?

I had never exchanged a single word with this NPC. He didn't seem to bear me any ill will, but he had never been especially friendly, either.

"Ah, yes. Nice to meet you, too."

Despite my lukewarm response, the guard's—or rather, Han Yeop's—face lit up.

What the hell? Why is he suddenly acting like this?

"I was there yesterday, too."

“There? Oh.”

He meant the duel. So many people had gathered that it wasn’t surprising Han Yeop had been among them.

“I watched from beginning to end. I saw how heroically you fought against that vicious Lee Seogeun of the Mount Heng Sword Sect!”

Vicious? Heroic?

That’s how it looked?

Honestly, from a modern man’s perspective, they were both as bad as each other.

No, I almost wanted to take Lee Seogeun’s side. As an older brother myself, no matter how fucking awful my little sister’s personality was, I’d lose my mind if she said she was dating a guy like Jin Taekyung.

Of course, the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s attitude and proposal had been absurd. That was why I had no choice but to fight.

“My heart pounded the entire time. I’m sure everyone else there felt the same way.”

Han Yeop continued, his face flushed with excitement. He seemed to be under a serious misunderstanding, and I had no idea when I was supposed to stop him.

“I once misunderstood you as well, Young Master. But now everyone in the family knows the truth.”

This time, I couldn’t help asking.

“The truth? What truth?”

“Well…”

Han Yeop lowered his voice to a whisper. His hot breath against my ear was bad enough, but what he said gave me goose bumps.

In other words—

“I’m the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s secret weapon?”

“Yes, yes!”

Han Yeop nodded furiously.

“My behavior until now was all an act, and ever since I was young, I’ve undergone bone-shattering training, becoming a man accomplished in both civil and martial arts, with virtue and righteousness, a sl—sl—”

I couldn’t bring myself to say that word. Han Yeop came to my rescue before my hands and feet could curl up from embarrassment.

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Everyone in the family knows now! You are Shanxi’s Sleeping Dragon, still hiding beneath the water instead of ascending to the heavens!”

Oh, please. Somebody save me. And don’t shout it out loud.

The Sleeping Dragon? Everyone in the family knew?

If I die, the cause of death will be death by embarrassment.

As I writhed in mental agony, Han Yeop asked with shining eyes,

“It’s true, isn’t it? I know it’s rude of me to ask, but just between us…”

This wouldn’t do. I decided to stamp out this ridiculous, cringe-inducing rumor, wherever it had come from, and opened my mouth.

“I don’t know who started such an absurd rumor, but…”

That was when it happened.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A rumor about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi is spreading throughout the Jin Family of Taiyuan.
Fame has risen by 10 due to the influence of the rumor.
The more people believe the rumor, the more Fame will rise.

I continued with a solemn expression.

“Every word of it is true.”

“I knew it! I believed it with all my heart!”

I watched Han Yeop walk away with rapture on his face and shed a single tear.

Fuck…

Ah, I miss my mom.

My duel with Lee Seogeun had taught me several things.

First.

I’m strong.

Early in the game, I had taken down the Heavenly Axe, the tutorial NPC, with a single strike. What had been a suspicion back then was now a certainty.

I was strong. Strong enough to defeat a Level 30 like Lee Seogeun without much trouble. The difference in combat experience had certainly played a part, but my basic stats were overwhelmingly superior.

Strength, Stamina, Agility. We were about even in all three, or I had a slight edge.

Stats. In other words, the difference in our abilities. In this game, I was a player, and I had continued to grow through the System.

By learning martial arts, training, and completing various Quests, I had raised my stats at remarkable speed. The result had been plain to see in the duel.

And second.

I don’t have enough internal energy.

In internal energy, Lee Seogeun had been ahead of me. Far ahead.

What the hell had he been eating growing up? I smashed him dozens of times with the shaft of my spear and pounded him one-sidedly from the mount, but he held out. He even counterattacked and managed to draw up more internal energy at the very end.

I currently have ten years of internal energy.

Lee Seogeun probably had twenty years—twice as much as I did. That led me to a third realization.

The difference in internal energy determines the stage of one's martial arts.

I had defeated Lee Seogeun, who was First Rate. But the realm displayed by the System still had me at Second Rate.

I thought the reason lay in internal energy. Once I raised the one ability I lacked, wouldn't my realm finally rise as well?

After organizing my thoughts that far, another idea suddenly occurred to me.

This is exactly like Hunter rank classification.

Every newly awakened Hunter had to visit a designated center to have their abilities, occupational aptitude, and mana capacity assessed. No matter how high their physical abilities were, a low mana capacity earned them a cold reception during the rank evaluation.

That was also why mages started at D-rank at the lowest. Because of their profession, mages had plenty of basic mana from the start.

Still, the game is better than reality.

At least you could grow here. Reality had no such thing. Even I had only managed to get lumped in with the E-ranks after working my ass off for seven years. I was still an F-rank Hunter.

Anyway, I had a rough plan now.

My stats are good enough. I'll cycle the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique whenever I have time and focus on Quests that reward EXP.

It had been more than a week since I was trapped in this godforsaken game. I had no idea what the hell was happening in the real world, but clearly no rescue was coming.

I needed to prepare properly and see this through.

"Open Quest window."

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Logout
You must now make your way through this harsh Murim.
Become stronger and more famous.
For the day that will come someday...
Grade: Main Quest
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Achieve the **First Rate** realm (Incomplete)
Reach Level 30 (17 / 30)
Reach Fame 500 (70 / 500)
Reward: Logout

“Ugh. This is brutal.”

I sat cross-legged. Two days remained before my seclusion ended. I intended to accumulate as much internal energy as possible.

SYSTEM

Fame has risen by 3 due to the influence of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi rumor.

The Fame-increase messages that chimed from time to time offered a small measure of comfort.

Late at night, the lights came on in the main assembly hall. At the request of the Lesser Family Head, a secret meeting of the family council was taking place.

The hour was late and the summons sudden, leaving several senior members wearing sour expressions.

“A sudden summons? What could this be about?”

“Exactly. Calling us here at this hour without even telling us why.”

“That’s what happens when the Lesser Family Head is still young. He doesn’t know procedure or etiquette.”

“He must be feeling rather full of himself after yesterday. Though I suppose his only weakness has disappeared. No one expected the Third Young Master to be so capable.”

“The Council of Elders must be disappointed. They were probably preparing to make a major move over the Third Young Master.”

“Hmph. Even now, the Head Elder should step forward and set the family straight.”

“Careful. Watch your tongue…”

At that moment, every sound abruptly stopped. The doors to the meeting room opened from both sides, and Jin Wikyung entered.

The senior members held widely differing opinions of their Lesser Family Head, but the silence that descended the instant he appeared proved that he possessed the qualities of a leader.

“Thank you all for answering my summons at this late hour.”

Jin Wikyung took the seat of honor and spoke his opening words, but he found it difficult to continue.

What should he say? Where should he begin, and how?

His head throbbed. But this was something he had to tell them.

“The reason I called everyone here today is…”

That was when a strange voice interrupted him.

“It must be because of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

It was a bizarre voice. At first it sounded like an old man’s, yet at the same time it seemed young—rough one moment and smooth the next. Beneath it all lay an inexplicable resonance.

Could it be…?

Jin Wikyung’s face twisted.

The doors to the meeting room, which had seemed as though they would never open again, began to part.

Step. Step. Step.

Five old men glided into the room. The moment everyone recognized the man at their head, they hurriedly rose and bowed.

“We pay our respects, Old Master!”

The Head Elder. He had appeared after keeping himself shut away from the world for years.

Chapter 17

Circulating qi.

It was a method of regulating one's energy by steadying one's breathing: drawing qi from outside the body, circulating it within, and accumulating it.

Right now, I was circulating qi using the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.

This still feels incredible every time.

I had never realized there were so many acupoints in my body.

I had once heard that the human body contained more than three hundred and sixty acupoints, but based on what I could feel while circulating qi through the cultivation technique, there were even more than that.

Is it because I'm a virtual game character?

Whatever.

The ten years of internal energy I drew up from my dantian circulated through my body. If internal energy was a car, then my acupoints were the highway. All I had to do was sit behind the wheel and press the accelerator.

The internal energy raced through the straight and curving pathways connecting the acupoints throughout my body before returning to my dantian.

And this is where the real problem starts.

I took a long, deep breath. Then I felt it.

Another mass of internal energy occupied my dantian like an enormous boulder, refusing to budge no matter how hard I willed it to.

What the hell are you?

It had been a mystery ever since I first circulated my qi—an unidentified energy that had settled in like it owned the place.

I didn't know where it had come from, how it had formed, or why I couldn't use it, but one thing was certain. This unidentified energy contained even more power than the ten years of internal energy I possessed.

Until now, I hadn't even dared touch it.

To be more precise, I hadn't intended to. Until a few days ago, I had been waiting for rescue while doing just enough to stay alive.

But things were different now.

I need more internal energy.

If I wanted to escape on my own, I had to fulfill the Logout Quest's condition: reaching the First Rate realm.

I also knew that I needed about as much internal energy as Lee Seogeun had to become First Rate.

I'll make it mine.

I cautiously began moving my internal energy.

The moment I sent it toward the unidentified energy, half anxious and half expectant, I realized something.

Not even close.

Internal energy was, strictly speaking, qi itself—something without a physical form. And yet the instant the two energies touched, I felt powerful rejection and resistance.

No. It was even pulling my energy in. At this rate, it was going to swallow mine instead.

Hey, hey, hey! Wait a second!

I hurriedly withdrew my internal energy and shook off the unidentified energy, which clung to me until the very end. At the same time, a System notification rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have trained the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.
Internal energy has risen slightly.
As a result of repeated training, Sinews and Meridians and Muscles and Bones have each increased by 1.

"What the hell was that?"

I calmed myself after the scare and opened my Status Window.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 17 Jin Taekyung
Occupation: Second Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 70
Titles: 4 (Title effects active)
Scion of a Prestigious Family — All stats +5, Fame +50
Family's Shame — All stats –5, Fame –50
Novice Trainee — Training speed +10%
Gambler — Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one contests
Strength: 65 **Stamina:** 65
Agility: 75 **Intelligence:** 10
Charm: 10 **Internal Energy:** 10 years
Remaining Points: 0

The numbers in my Status Window were fairly impressive by now.

I had gained three levels all at once through the Duel Quest, then distributed the thirty points equally among Strength, Stamina, and Agility.

But looking at the Status Window still left a bitter taste in my mouth.

My internal energy is the only thing that hasn't changed.

This damn System kept saying that my internal energy had risen, but the amount displayed in the Status Window remained exactly the same.

Do I need to take a spirit pill, an elixir, or something?

I thought of Jin Wikyung. If I screwed up my courage and said, *Hyung, give me one spirit pill,*[69] I didn't think he would refuse me outright.

I'd ask him the next time I saw him. I would also ask about the unidentified energy inside my dantian.

Krrrummble.

At that moment, the entrance to the training hall opened, and two people stepped inside.

"Um, Young Master Jin?"

It was Han Yeop. Behind him stood a martial artist I had never seen before. The man spoke in a blunt tone that matched his appearance.

"The Lesser Family Head commands you to attend the family council."

"The Lesser Family Head?"

That worked out perfectly. There was something I wanted to ask him about.

"It is beyond doubt. A few bones were broken, and there was some minor internal damage, but that level of injury could never—"

"Are you sure? Will you stake your name as the Medicine King Hall Master on it?"

"I said it's true! I examined him myself!"

"Then that settles it. Why are you talking down to me? I treat you with respect because you're a fellow Hall Master, and now you think I'm a joke!"

"You were the one who started talking down to me, White Tiger Hall Master!"

I stared blankly at the ceiling of the meeting room. The shouts and curses flying from every direction made my ears ring.

What the hell is this?

This wasn't what I had imagined a family council would be like. I had pictured a quiet, orderly atmosphere where everyone exchanged opinions and searched for common ground…

"You think all Hall Masters are equal? You're nothing but a mere physician!"

[69] *Hyung* is a term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“Listen to this young bastard. I ought to shove a large needle straight into your Huiyin Acupoint!”[70]

Two men in their forties or fifties, both with receding, M-shaped hairlines, were grabbing each other by the collars and shaking one another. Just watching them made my head hurt.

The problem was that scenes like this were unfolding all over the room.

Maybe that was why most of the people there didn’t seem to notice me opening the door and taking my seat.

—You’re here?

The voice seemed to enter through my head rather than my ears. It was Sound Transmission.

I turned my head and met Jin Wikyung’s gaze from the seat of honor. He gave me a tired smile.

—It’s a madhouse, isn’t it?

No kidding. Why did you call me into this madhouse, man?

When I shot him a reproachful look, Jin Wikyung sent another message through Sound Transmission, his expression turning sheepish.

—I couldn’t help it. The Council of Elders demanded your attendance. In any case… you are involved in this matter.

The Council of Elders? I’m involved in this matter?

What matter am I involved in…? Oh. The Mount Heng Sword Sect?

I quickly pieced things together amid the shouting and cursing.

If there was one recent incident connected to me, it was the Mount Heng Sword Sect. And because of that incident, this Council of Elders or whatever it was had summoned me.

That had to be it.

Come to think of it, there are some old men here I’ve never seen before.

There were four of them. Every one had a face covered in age spots and hair that had gone completely white.

They watched the men with the M-shaped hairlines grab each other by the collars with cold eyes. Anyone could see it was a nursing home—or rather, the Council of Elders.

—And… the Head Elder is here.

I turned toward Jin Wikyung without thinking, then flinched.

What the hell? Where did that old man come from?

When had he gotten there? I had only just noticed that there were two seats of honor today. An old man was sitting to Jin Wikyung’s right, staring at me. His gaze made my face prickle.

[70] The Huiyin Acupoint is located on the perineum, between the genitals and the anus.

Is that old man the Head Elder?

White hair, a white beard, and white eyebrows. He looked like an immortal who had stepped out of an old painting. His back was straight, his shoulders broad, and his skin so taut that he hardly seemed old at all.

But why is he staring at me so intently?

I narrowed my eyes and started to glare back at the Head Elder…

Then I quietly looked away.

Not because I thought I would lose if we locked eyes. It was respect for my elders. Respect for my elders. Really.

I'll just keep my head down.

Jin Wikyung's Sound Transmission continued in the meantime.

—You may not know this because you lost your memory, but the Head Elder is your great-uncle and the highest-ranking elder in the family. Be especially careful with your words and actions.

I hadn't even seen my father's face, and now I had a great-uncle.

Maybe this place had relatives by marriage, distant cousins, and every kind of obscure uncle, too.

I gave Jin Wikyung a small nod.

—And… you must not be flustered by anything that happens from this point onward. Calmly tell them only the truth. Do you understand?

I didn't know exactly what was going on, but one thing was certain: Jin Wikyung was on my side.

I nodded again, and Jin Wikyung rose with a faint smile.

"Silence, everyone."

His voice, infused with internal energy, swept across the meeting hall.

"This is a family council of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and we have gathered to discuss a grave matter. Since our witness has arrived, I intend to begin the interrogation."

The meeting hall had gone quiet without me noticing. With everyone's attention focused on him, Jin Wikyung spoke.

"By the authority of the Lesser Family Head and current acting Family Head, I begin this interrogation. Third Young Master Jin Taekyung, step forward."

I felt everyone's eyes on me as I walked forward. I had expected this much. They hadn't summoned me for no reason.

But…

"I ask you this. Were you the one who poisoned Lee Seogeun of the Mount Heng Sword Sect to death?"

That was something I hadn't expected.

“No.”

I barely managed to force the word out. My thoughts were a mess from the sudden question.

Lee Seogeun was dead? Poisoned, at that?

“Tell us the truth. If it turns out to be a lie…”

“I have nothing to do with Lee Seogeun’s poisoning.”

My answer was as sharp as a blade. Jin Wikyung let out a sigh of relief.

—Keep doing exactly this.

The interrogation proceeded quickly. They asked questions, and I answered them.

Starting with Jin Wikyung, they fired one question after another at me.

About half of the questions concerned whether I had been involved in poisoning Lee Seogeun, and I continued to deny it.

Because it was true.

Just in case, I secretly opened my System Window to check. I was certain of it. None of my martial arts or abilities had anything to do with poison. I didn’t have any such Items, either.

That was why I could answer without hesitation.

“No.”

The problem was that, at some point, the atmosphere in the meeting hall began to take a strange turn.

“Do you have any evidence to prove it?”

“Evidence?”

White Tiger Hall Master, was it? The man whose name I didn’t even know stared at me with obvious displeasure.

“That is correct. Evidence. I mean evidence that would prove the Third Young Master’s innocence.”

What the hell is this bastard talking about?

“Why do I have to prove it?”

“What?”

“Don’t talk down to me.”

“Listen here, Third Young Master!”

“You’re free to suspect me, but shouldn’t you be the ones looking for evidence? Am I wrong?”

I’d been letting it slide, and now these bastards thought I was some kind of wrapping cloth?[71]

[71] The Korean line plays on *boja* (“let’s see”) and *bojagi*, a traditional wrapping cloth.

Fuming, I glared at the White Tiger Hall Master as he sat down, then noticed something strange.

Well, well. Look at this.

The White Tiger Hall Master kept stealing glances at the old men of the Council of Elders.

Curiously, everyone who had been pressing and interrogating me was doing something similar.

Nearly half the people in attendance were acting this way. It was getting difficult to pretend I hadn't noticed.

So this is a factional struggle.

The Council of Elders and Jin Wikyung.

Even now, a power struggle was taking place between the elders of the family and a Lesser Family Head young enough to be their grandson.

What a family.

Only a few people remained to question me. The problem was who those people were.

Faces covered in age spots. Canny, experienced eyes.

The old men of the Council of Elders.

The oldest and fattest of them opened his mouth.

"Enough of these pointless questions and answers. There is only one thing this old man wishes to ask. Where did this matter begin?"

The senior members allied with the Council of Elders answered as if they had been waiting for the question.

"The Third Young Master."

"Who was it that dragged our family's reputation through the mud with his dissolute words and conduct?"

"The Third Young Master."

The same answer came from several places around the room.

"Then who was it that laid a hand on the treasured jewel the Mount Heng Sword Sect held in its palm and brought us to this crisis?"

"…"

Just kill me already, you bastards.

Chapter 18

The atmosphere grew worse by the second.

“The important thing is that the duel was fair!”

“Fair? Since when is using poison considered fair? What is this, the Sichuan Tang Clan?”

“The man himself said he didn’t do it! And as the Medicine King Hall Master said earlier, Lee Seogeun was perfectly fine—”

“Of course the Third Young Master would deny it. And how can you trust that quack?”

“A quack? You bastard!”

Then one particularly agitated voice pierced my ears.

“If necessary, we should prevent the war even if it means offering up the Third Young Master’s head!”

…What?

“What outrageous nonsense!”

“Am I wrong? Let’s admit it already. The Mount Heng Sword Sect is stronger than our family. If war breaks out, hundreds will be killed or injured, and in the worst case, our family will be wiped out. If we hand over the Third Young Master, who caused all this, won’t that settle everything?”

Was that supposed to be speech or a fart? It had been a while since I’d heard bullshit that impressive. The back of my neck tightened, and my chest began to ache.

But someone else stepped forward before I could.

“What did you just say?”

His voice was quiet, but it carried power. Its very quietness made it all the clearer.

It was Jin Wikyung. He looked around the room, his face expressionless.

“Whose. Head. Did you say we should offer?”

Frost coated every clipped syllable. The atmosphere was so chilling that even I shivered, but the White Tiger Hall Master immediately spoke up.

“Why, obviously the Third Young Master, the chief culprit behind this—ah.”

That bastard was bald, and he couldn’t read the room either. The White Tiger Hall Master let his words trail off, but it was already too late.

“So you intend to offer the Third Young Master’s head to the Mount Heng Sword Sect over something that hasn’t even been confirmed? Is that something a hall master of this family should say?”

“No, that isn’t what I meant…”

Overwhelmed by Jin Wikyung’s aura, the White Tiger Hall Master avoided his gaze. Jin Wikyung stared silently at him.

He wasn’t normally like this, which made him even scarier now that he was angry.

The White Tiger Hall Master’s deathly pale face made me feel as though ten years of indigestion had finally cleared. Jin Wikyung rose from his seat and looked coldly over the gathering.

“You all know the truth already.”

He swept his gaze across the room and spoke with conviction.

“The duel was fair, and Lee Seogeun’s poisoning was a conspiracy. Knowing that, are you suggesting we surrender to them out of fear?”

The members of the Council of Elders faction avoided his gaze. Jin Wikyung’s sneer deepened.

“I don’t know who placed it in their hands, but the Mount Heng Sword Sect now holds the hilt of a sword called justification. Whether they strike today or tomorrow—or whether the sword has already been drawn—it’s too late for us to turn this around. There is only one thing we can do. Fight back.”

“…”

“Do you want to live? Do you want to protect the family? If you truly do, ready the martial artists and prepare for war. Otherwise, cut off my head and my younger brother’s and offer them up. If wealth and glory are all you desire, I suppose that isn’t a bad option.”

A suffocating silence seized the main assembly hall.

If one person hadn’t spoken the next moment, we might have remained crushed beneath that silence for hours.

“Excellent.”

It was the man who had silently watched everything unfold until now.

The Head Elder.

The Head Elder.

Someone I needed to watch. The family’s highest-ranking elder and the head of the Council of Elders.

I recalled Jin Wikyung’s earlier Sound Transmission.

He told me to be careful.

Among all the NPCs, Jin Wikyung was my greatest ally and adviser.

I hadn’t taken his warning lightly. Whenever I had the chance, I kept an eye on the Head Elder.

And I reached one conclusion.

Fuck, I can’t figure him out at all.

If someone asked me to count every NPC I’d encountered since starting this godforsaken game, the number would easily exceed a hundred.

They each had their own expressions and personalities. The servant I met at the pleasure house wore the weary professional smile of someone ground down by life. The coachman who brought me here had a bumbling side, while the senior members of the family were surprisingly simple and hot-tempered.

But the Head Elder…

I can't read his expression.

He merely watched everything with that strange smile of his.

When the interrogation began. When the senior members of the different factions shouted at one another. Even now.

Clap. Clap. Clap.

The Head Elder's vigorous applause rang through the hall.

"I had always thought of you as a mere youngster, but before I knew it, the Lesser Family Head had grown into such a commanding martial artist. Excellent. That is how the Lesser Family Head of our family should conduct himself."

"I can only apologize for showing you such an unseemly side."

"Excessive humility can be mistaken for arrogance. You have nothing to apologize for."

Despite the Head Elder's praise, Jin Wikyung's expression remained stiff.

"May this old man add a word? What do you think, Lesser Family Head?"

"I will take it to heart."

As the Head Elder slowly rose, dozens of pairs of eyes fixed on him.

He was the family's most senior elder. In authority and standing within the family, he might even surpass Jin Wikyung.

The biggest problem was that he led the opposing faction, the Council of Elders.

Fuck. I'm screwed.

I began turning toward the door in preparation for the worst when the Head Elder's first words reached my ears.

"You're rotten to the core."

Huh?

I whipped my head around. The Head Elder still wore his usual strange smile.

Did I hear him wrong?

But I hadn't.

"Even beasts join forces and fight when an enemy enters their den. And yet men who are supposedly senior members of this family offer up the head of a direct-line member as a solution to stop a war. Heh. So men like this sit in our family council."

"N-no, Old Master. You misunderstand. It was merely…"

"White Tiger Hall Master."

At the Head Elder's icy call, the White Tiger Hall Master stiffened.

“Was I away for too long? Or is this what happened because the Family Head was absent?”

“N-no, Old Master.”

Judging by his expression alone, he looked like some ripped old man at the gym asking if you’d eaten. But his words were downright vicious.

What the hell is this?

What was going on? Why was he taking our side?

I darted my eyes around, but everyone else looked just as confused as I was. Both factions were visibly flustered.

“What do you think, Lesser Family Head?”

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“If war is now inevitable, our first priority should be putting our own house in order. Shouldn’t we begin by cutting off the heads of those men who are little better than traitors?”

In the frozen silence, Jin Wikyung stared at the Head Elder for a long moment before letting out his answer like a sigh.

“That cannot be done.”

Whew. The White Tiger Hall Master breathed a sigh of relief.

Considering that he’d just suggested offering up my head, I was a little disappointed.

Should I suggest killing just him?

“Those men not only framed a direct-line member of the family, but even argued we should hand him over to the enemy. Don’t you think that is too lenient a response?”

“They have served our family faithfully for many years. I will consider their words a thoughtless remark made in the heat of the moment.”

The Head Elder laughed heartily.

“A thoughtless remark. A thoughtless remark, indeed. Yes, the Lesser Family Head’s capacity is greater than I imagined. You are truly worthy of your position. In that case, I will not hold them accountable. I offer my thanks to the Lesser Family Head for magnanimously forgiving the thoughtless words of these old men.”

When the Head Elder bowed, the others frantically waved their hands and bent at the waist in return.

“Oh, Old Master, please. We were the ones who failed to think matters through.”

“Please don’t do this.”

“You’re only making us more ashamed. Please…”

“Old Master…!”

Jin Wikyung was the one who had spared them, yet they were making a huge fuss over the Head Elder.

Go on. Put on a show. What a performance.

I clicked my tongue inwardly as I watched the spectacle.

Wait. A show?

An indescribable sense of wrongness swept over me. I hurriedly examined the people gathered around the Head Elder.

And then I saw it.

The faint smiles flickering across the lips of the Council of Elders members who had hounded me earlier.

No way…

Was this planned? All of it?

What were they trying to accomplish? Why? Countless questions rose and vanished. My thoughts were a complete mess.

Does Jin Wikyung know something?

I didn't even need to turn and look for him. The Head Elder was already raising Jin Wikyung's hand high in the air and shouting.

"With the Family Head absent, the Lesser Family Head is effectively our Family Head. I support him in this matter. If we unite behind him, then no matter how formidable our enemies may be, they will never dare challenge the Jin Family!"

The heated atmosphere. The chanting and cheers.

Where had I seen this before?

It all felt strangely familiar.

And then—

"Thank you."

The moment I saw the corners of Jin Wikyung's mouth tremble and the Head Elder's strange smile, I realized what it reminded me of.

An election campaign.

The Head Elder's figure overlapped with the politicians I'd seen on television.

The whole thing left a bad taste in my mouth, but once the Head Elder raised Jin Wikyung's hand, the meeting proceeded at a rapid pace.

All discussion of the duel, which the Council of Elders faction had so stubbornly dragged out, vanished. Instead, the meeting focused on the assumption that war was coming.

"How many men are currently available?"

"If we recall the martial artists stationed outside… roughly two hundred."

Two hundred?

I was impressed by the unexpectedly large number, but the next question shut me up.

“And if we select only elites of First Rate or higher?”

“Fewer than twenty. Of course, the number would be different if we included everyone present.”

Including the senior members, there were around thirty or forty First Rate masters.

I didn’t know much about how things worked here, but that seemed like a respectable number.

Just what I’d expect from an old, prestigious great family. Two hundred years of accumulated strength didn’t simply vanish.

“What about the Mount Heng Sword Sect?”

“At least three hundred martial artists have been confirmed so far.”

Three hundred. And that was the minimum, which put them more than a hundred men ahead.

But it was fine. Fights came down to numbers anyway—

“And they have more than fifty First Rate martial artists.”

This war was going to be tough.

Still, with masters like Jin Wikyung and Wipeng, we had a chance. They were high-level NPCs beyond the reach of my Qi Sense. The Head Elder probably belonged in the same category.

“Our family has three Peak masters in total: the Lesser Family Head, the Head Elder, and Sir Wipeng. The Mount Heng Sword Sect has five.”

…Fuck this. I couldn’t do it.

What? An old, prestigious great family? Two hundred years of history?

What the hell had these bastards been doing for two hundred years? From what I’d heard, the Mount Heng Sword Sect hadn’t even existed for thirty, yet their forces didn’t merely outmatch ours.

We were being steamrolled. Steamrolled.

Did the Black Death sweep through here last year or something?

Plague or no plague, I felt like I was about to lose my mind. As I stared at the yellowed ceiling of the meeting hall, I made a sudden decision.

I need to run.

Around four in the morning should do. Once everyone was asleep, I’d sneak over the wall and run as far away as possible.

At my current level, I could easily deal with five or six martial artists around the Heavenly Axe’s level.

I could scour every mountain I came across and rack up EXP and Fame—

“M-Mount Heng! A messenger pigeon has arrived from the Mount Heng Sword Sect!”

A martial artist had rushed into the hall and shouted.

Someone took the rolled sheet of paper and unfurled it. Red characters, as though written in blood, came into view.

Even without the System translating them, I could read them.

> **Enemies Who Cannot Live Beneath the Same Sky**

Irreconcilable enemies beneath heaven.

Jin Wikyung spoke with a grim expression.

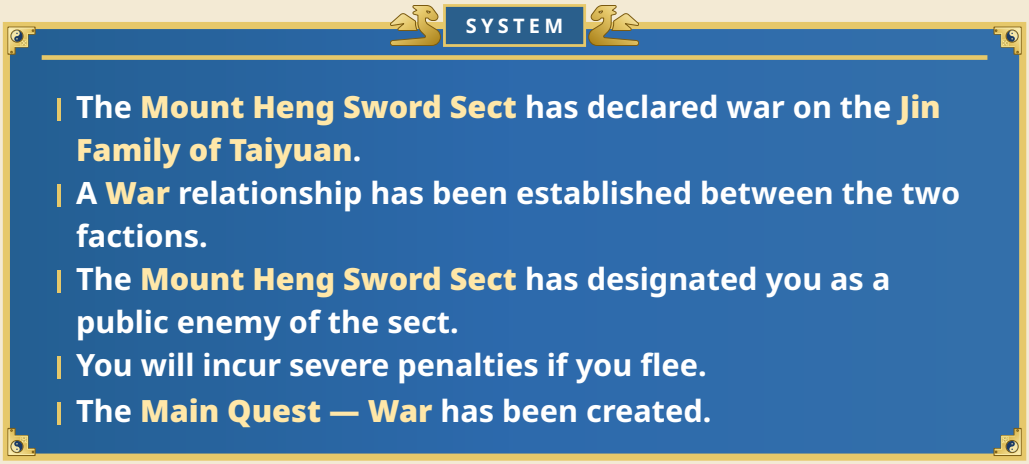
“From this moment onward, our family enters a state of war. Without my seal, no one may enter or leave the family grounds, regardless of rank or position. Maintain the strictest vigilance. Do not let so much as a single ant through. Understood?”

“Yes!”

“…”

With my mind half gone, I heard a System notification ring in my ears.

Ding.



…Heh. Heh heh heh.

Chapter 19

SYSTEM

Quest
War
A war that will decide the fate of two families has begun. In Murim, strength is the only way to prove yourself! Those who survive are strong, and only the strong will survive. May fortune favor you in battle.
Grade: Main Quest
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Surrender or destruction of the Mount Heng Sword Sect (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

Jin Wikyung spoke as I stared fixedly at the Quest Window.

“You look very tired.”

Tired? I was amazed that my current state of mind could be summed up in such a simple word.

Instead of answering, I looked at the steaming teacup.

The water’s already been spilled.

I had done my best, but I hadn’t been able to stop the war. The family council had turned into a war council, and with the Head Elder’s full support, Jin Wikyung had taken command without hesitation.

> Martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, assemble at the main family residence immediately!

Around daybreak, dozens of messenger pigeons took to the sky and messengers rode hard on horseback. A tight security net spread across the area.

When the family council finally broke up amid that tense atmosphere, Jin Wikyung, Wipeng, and I moved to the Lesser Family Head’s office.

“It was bound to happen someday. This isn’t your fault, Taekyung.”

Jin Wikyung’s warm words almost brought tears to my eyes. Not because I was moved, but because I felt so wronged.

Of course it wasn’t my fault!

And while we were on the subject, why the hell did that “bound to happen someday” have to happen now?

While I fumed inwardly, Wipeng suddenly spoke.

“My lord.”

“What is it?”

“The Head Elder… I simply cannot fathom his intentions.”

The Head Elder. The instant I heard that name, every other thought vanished. Of all the NPCs I had encountered in this game, he was the most unsettling.

At times, he seemed genuinely devoted to the family. At others, he reeked of a politician maneuvering for his own benefit.

I cautiously asked, “What kind of person is the Head Elder?”

“He is a martial artist of a high realm, and his schemes run deep. You could call him one of the most dangerous kinds of people in Murim.”

“He’s that dangerous?”

Jin Wikyung nodded gravely.

“Even the other Elders are little more than the Head Elder’s hands and feet. He rarely reveals himself, yet he has used the Council of Elders to win over influential members and bring them under his command. He has been doing so for decades.”

“Then his supporting us at the family council…”

“We cannot know for certain, but he must have some ulterior motive. Of that, I am sure.”

“We should have killed them all.”

Wipeng cut in abruptly, his voice cold.

“They are disloyal rebels. When the Head Elder proposed killing them, I honestly hoped you would accept.”

I had felt the same way. But that had merely been the Head Elder’s clever way of speaking—a suggestion that perhaps we should back down at this point.

If Jin Wikyung had pretended to be insane and accepted that proposal, the result would have been obvious.

“A bloodbath would have followed.”

“I know. That’s why I held back.”

The Jin Family of Taiyuan’s leadership would have split in two and continued fighting until they killed one another. If we lost, we would die. Even if we won, we would suffer tremendous damage.

Maybe that was exactly what the Head Elder wanted.

The Head Elder. An invisible hand.

The thought sent a chill down my spine. It fit the image I had formed of him perfectly.

A hyena of a politician, stepping back and waiting for his moment.

Jin Wikyung tilted his teacup.

“But that is only a guess. We do not know what the Head Elder truly intends. He is still one of the family’s elders, and a powerful ally. Be wary of him, but do not make an enemy of him. For now, we need to overcome the situation rather than distrust everyone around us.”

He was telling me to see the forest, not the trees.

The problem was, the forest itself wasn’t exactly in good shape.

As if he had read my thoughts, Wipeng brought up that very subject.

“The situation is grim as well. According to our outside sources, rumors that Lee Seogeun was poisoned to death are spreading, and our family’s reputation is plummeting.”

“In only half a day?”

“Yes. All of Shanxi Province is in an uproar.”

Concern clouded Jin Wikyung’s face.

“That is fast. Far too fast. Someone is definitely behind this.”

There was no internet here, and yet rumors had already spread across this vast land. It was certainly strange.

An invisible enemy.

Who could it be? A third faction? A scheme staged by the Mount Heng Sword Sect itself?

I hoped it was the latter if possible. Nothing was more dangerous than an enemy who remained unseen.

“The public still seems unsure what to believe, but the other sects…”

“Still no replies?”

Wipeng lowered his head instead of answering.

As soon as Jin Wikyung learned of Lee Seogeun’s poisoning, he had sent requests for aid to the other small and mid-sized sects in Shanxi Province. Apparently, every last one of them had come to nothing.

This just keeps getting worse.

Do I really need to run?

I was looking out the window, thinking that, when—

Flap, flap.

A pigeon landed on the windowsill with a flutter of wings.

“…Looks like we got a reply.”

The Jin Family of Taiyuan.

As the carriage approached the grand signboard emblazoned with majestic calligraphy and the martial artists guarding the main gate with stern auras, the coachman slackened the reins.

“Stop! State your identity and purpose!”

The gate guard called out loudly and blocked the carriage. Given the circumstances, there was tension in his voice.

And there was something else.

They’re no ordinary visitors.

The coachman holding the reins gave off the unmistakable air of a trained martial artist, while the four-horse carriage was both lavish and dignified.

But why do they look familiar?

The coachman and the carriage alike. Where had he seen them before?

The question vanished the moment he saw the coachman’s sharp eyes. That aura, that gaze. This was certainly no ordinary visitor.

The gate guard swallowed and spoke again.

“Please state your identity and purpose.”

The carriage door opened, and a red silk slipper touched lightly to the ground.

Then a voice as gentle as a spring breeze drifted into the guard’s ear.

“I’m from Honghwaru. My name is a secret.”

Her face appeared along with her voice.

The gate guard’s eyes went glassy. He wasn’t the only one. Everyone who saw the woman reacted the same way.

A vacant voice escaped the gate guard’s mouth.

“Ah, a secret… Then what brings you here?”

The woman—Wolhwa—answered with a bewitching smile.

“Hmm. To collect an unpaid tab?”

“How have you been? Didn’t you miss me?”

I froze halfway to my feet.

A face I could never forget. And one that had no business being here.

“Wolhwa?”

The first NPC I had met in this game. A courtesan at Honghwaru and my—Jin Taekyung’s—pinky.[72] That thing.

Why is noona[73] coming out of there…?

“So you do remember me. Our Young Master Jin.”

---

[72] In Korea, a raised pinky can refer to someone’s girlfriend or mistress.

[73] *Noona* is a familiar Korean term a man uses for an older woman.

Wolhwa giggled. She was pretty, her laugh was pretty, and when a pretty girl laughed, she looked even prettier…

No, this is not the time for that.

I whispered in a hushed voice.

“What are you doing here? No, forget it. Leave. Get out.”

I nudged Wolhwa repeatedly with my elbow.

This is driving me insane.

Of all times, she had to show up now.

The entire family was on high alert. If word got around that I had summoned a courtesan, I couldn’t even imagine what would happen to my reputation. Just thinking about it made me dizzy.

“Stop poking me. It tickles.”

“Fine, so hurry up and leave. There are other people here. What are you trying to pull, barging in all of a sudden? We’re expecting an important guest, too.”

The timing was goddamn awful. I was in the Lesser Family Head’s office, waiting for a guest from a sect called the Lower District Sect.

Naturally, Jin Wikyung and Wipeng were there with me.

“Taekyung.”

Jin Wikyung called my name. Without even turning around, I hurriedly waved my hands.

“Ah, it’s not what you think. I didn’t call her. She says she’s leaving now. Right?”

Wolhwa’s laughter rose in pitch.

“Our Young Master Jin is as adorable as ever. But you’ve got it wrong. I came here on business.”

“Hey, none of that ‘our Young Master Jin’ stuff. I’m going to live chastely from today onward. I won’t have any business with your side anymore, so hurry up and leave.”

“Hmm. No.”

Then there was no helping it. I would have to move her by force.

In desperation, I wrapped my arms around Wolhwa’s waist and hoisted her up—

“Huh?”

What the hell? Why couldn’t I lift her?

Wolhwa looked slender, but was she so big-boned that she weighed a lot?

That’s bullshit.

How high was my Strength stat? With pure physical strength alone, I could grind a rock into powder. And yet I couldn’t lift one female NPC, which meant—

“Taekyung?”

Ignoring Jin Wikyung’s second call, I furtively let go and heightened my Qi Sense.

“Ahahahahaha! This is driving me insane!”

As Wolhwa laughed herself to death, a Level Window appeared above her head. At the same time, I heard Jin Wikyung call my name for the third time.

“Taekyung, greet her. She is the Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect’s Shanxi branch…”

Ah. Ahhh.

I want to die.

“Greetings. I am Wolhwa, Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect’s Shanxi branch.”

Eun Sowol.

No, for now, let’s just call her Wolhwa.

She was different from how she had acted until now. Every movement carried the grace and elegance of a noblewoman.

“I am Jin Wikyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“I’m Wipeng.”

I kept my mouth shut like mute Samryong,[74] and Wolhwa flashed me a grin.

It was an ominous grin.

Don’t. Don’t smile.

Don’t talk to me. Please don’t.

“It seems there is still one person I haven’t been introduced to.”

Her gaze stung. Someone stepped on my foot beneath the table.

Feeling as though I were coughing up blood, I forced myself to speak.

“…I’m Jin Taekyung.”

“Yes. I look forward to getting along with you too, Young Master Jin.”

“Ahem.”

With a cough, Jin Wikyung glanced at me.

“I didn’t realize you were acquainted with my younger brother.”

“He’s a regular at our establishment—the Honghwaru in Taiyuan. It also serves as our sect’s Shanxi branch.”

“Ah. A regular…”

[74] Samryong is the mute protagonist of a well-known Korean short story; his name literally means “Three Dragons.”

I avoided everyone's gaze. Wolhwa let out a burst of laughter, then brought up the real subject.

"Shall we talk business now?"

I had felt it several times before, but she really was a refreshingly direct woman. Jin Wikyung and Wipeng also turned their attention away from me and joined the conversation.

"First, allow me to offer my sincere thanks for the Lower District Sect's assistance."

"Think nothing of it."

"But may I ask why you wish to help our family?"

Wolhwa smiled sweetly at Jin Wikyung's question.

"The reason… I will tell you if necessary. First, we are doing this for our sect's benefit."

"Benefit. What specific compensation do you want?"

"Half of the shops and assets owned by the Mount Heng Sword Sect."

"Good."

"My lord!"

Wipeng hurriedly stepped forward, but Jin Wikyung paid him no heed.

Even Wolhwa looked slightly surprised.

"That was quick."

"I have wagered everything our family has."

"Has this already been agreed upon?"

"I am the Lesser Family Head. With Father absent, I hold the authority of the acting Family Head."

"I hear the opposition within your family is considerable. The Council of Elders, for example?"

"As expected of the Lower District Sect. Your information travels fast."

"It cannot be helped. Information is essential if one hopes to survive in this harsh Murim. We need at least this much savvy to make a living, don't we?"

As I watched Wolhwa smile, a thought suddenly occurred to me.

That information. Did I—or rather, did Jin Taekyung—let it slip?

I had been wondering where I had heard the name Lower District Sect before. It was one of those information-gathering sects that appeared all the time in martial-arts novels. In other words, Wolhwa, its Branch Leader, was a veteran information broker.

On top of that, she was an outstanding Level 50 martial artist. A woman like her had disguised herself as a courtesan to meet a guy like Jin Taekyung?

Even a dog would laugh at that.

I stared at Wolhwa.

She was dazzling enough to make me wonder if a goddess had descended from heaven. Every time she smiled, I thought of a rose. Only now could I see the sharp thorns hidden beneath all that splendor.

Jin Wikyung spoke, his expression stiff.

“Then tell us the second reason.”

Wolhwa answered with her usual radiant smile.

“Because I like Young Master Jin.”

“Excuse me?”

“He’s young, handsome, well-built, and has such a cute personality.”

“…”

“…”

How much of that was sincere, and how much was a joke?

Chapter 20

The hour-long negotiation was finally drawing to a close.

“Half the shops owned by the Mount Heng Sword Sect, plus exclusive rights to the pleasure district. Is that correct?”

“Correct. And your sect?”

“From this moment onward, we will sell no information to any sect in Shanxi Province other than the Jin Family of Taiyuan. We will also devote all our resources to gathering and delivering information about the war.”

These were the terms they had settled on after dozens of rounds of back-and-forth.

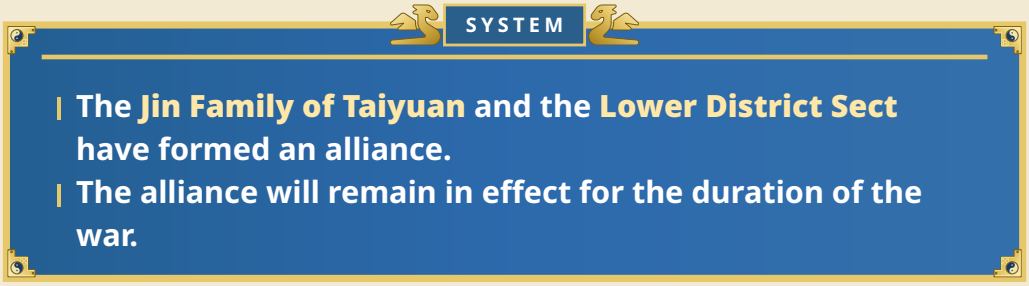
Jin Wikyung and Wolhwa carefully checked everything one last time for loopholes, then drew up and exchanged the document.

“We’re officially in the same boat now. I look forward to working with you, Lesser Family Head.”

“Likewise.”

The moment they shook hands—

Ding.



Even this gets a notification.

Then again, something similar had appeared when the war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect began.

With the Lower District Sect joining us, have our chances of winning gone up a little?

The Lower District Sect specialized in information.

Wolhwa had confidently claimed that all information in Shanxi Province passed through her hands. If that was true, they would be an enormous help.

Nothing is more important than information.

I didn’t know how things worked in Murim, but I knew that much. Depending on how it was used, information could be a sword, a shield, or even a bomb capable of turning the tide all at once.

Hopefully, Wolhwa would bring us something like that.

“Then I’ll be taking my leave.”

“Please understand that I can’t go far while people are watching.”

“Of course.”

It's finally over.

Wipeng bowed with his usual impassive expression, and I offered an awkward half-bow of my own.

"Goodbye."

Wolhwa's eyes curved into crescents as she looked at me.

"Young Master Jin, you have to come with me."

"Huh?"

"Aren't you going to see me off?"

"…Why would I?"

"Because we spent such a hot night together?"

The blunt hit left me stunned for a moment. I'd told this woman to bring us information, so why was the first thing she spread X-rated information?

And in front of everyone, too.

"Oh?"

"A h-hot night? Together?"

Wipeng looked between Wolhwa and me with open interest, while an earthquake shook Jin Wikyung's pupils.

"Taekyung, is that true? Is it really true?"

After a long silence, I answered.

"I'll see her out."

I grabbed Wolhwa by the wrist and dashed out. Behind me, Jin Wikyung's mournful voice echoed.

"My little brother!"

Wolhwa was a rare beauty. With her slender figure and splendid clothing, she couldn't help but draw attention.

"Did our family always have a beauty like that?"

"Of course not. She's an outsider."

"An outsider?"

"Yeah. A friend at the Gate Guard Pavilion says she's a courtesan from Honghwaru."

"Ah, that ridiculously expensive Honghwaru. I know the place. Wait, why would a courtesan come here now?"

"They say she came to collect the Third Young Master's unpaid tab. She probably wants her money before the fighting turns into all-out war."

"…Huh. The Third Young Master really gets up to all kinds of things, doesn't he?"

Their whispers wormed their way into my ears. Wolhwa, who had been walking ahead and humming to herself, suddenly glanced back.

“Young Master Jin, why are you so far behind?”

I answered sullenly.

“If we walk together, people will get the wrong idea. They’re already spreading ridiculous rumors…”

“Oh, you mean the unpaid tab?”

Yeah. That.

“That rumor isn’t false.”

Wolhwa smiled brightly.

“When the gate guards asked why I’d come, I told them I was here to collect an unpaid tab. It isn’t a complete lie.”

“What?”

“Were you planning to announce our alliance to the whole world?”

“…No.”

But why did she have to use my name? My image was already a complete disaster.

If a rumor like this spread in the middle of a war, I’d never be able to deny it. My reputation as a piece of trash would be set in stone.

“You’ve already been falsely accused of poisoning someone. Compared to that, being known as a courtesan’s kept man isn’t so bad. Given your usual behavior, everyone will find it believable.”

That was strangely persuasive. I found myself nodding, only to realize that something in her words felt off.

“Falsely accused?”

Come to think of it, she hadn’t mentioned Lee Seogeun even once. She had negotiated the terms like a meticulous businesswoman, then formed an alliance with us as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

What exactly is she relying on?

Wolhwa smiled faintly at my suspicious look.

“Young Master Jin, have you forgotten who I am?”

“The Lower District Sect’s Shanxi Branch Leader…”

My eyes widened.

Information. She had information.

Information proving I wasn’t the culprit!

I hurried to Wolhwa’s side.

“Can you clear my name? Do you really have information like that?”

Lee Seogeun’s poisoning had started this war. If we could prove that the whole thing was someone else’s conspiracy, we could stop it.

But Wolhwa's next words shattered that hope.

"No. I don't."

What?

"Then why did you form an alliance with us?"

"Because I'm a merchant."

Wolhwa continued in a light, cheerful voice.

"We of the Lower District Sect are merchants at heart. We act according to a strict calculation of profit and loss."

"Then this makes even less sense."

"Oh? Why?"

"The Mount Heng Sword Sect is stronger than we are. If you're weighing profit and loss, shouldn't you side with them?"

"You're honest. Or perhaps I should say naïve."

Wolhwa let out a quiet laugh.

"This is an investment. It's the result of placing both sides on a scale and analyzing them coldly."

"So as long as you profit, nothing else matters? Even if I really did poison Lee Seogeun?"

"Young Master Jin, what do you think it means that the Lower District Sect's Shanxi branch devoted all its resources to this investigation, yet still couldn't uncover the truth?"

I hesitated, but Wolhwa didn't wait for an answer.

"It's simple. Either you're truly innocent, or you covered your tracks so thoroughly that not even we could find them."

"Ah."

"Neither possibility is a loss for me. If it's the former, then your side has legitimacy. If it's the latter, then it proves the Jin Family of Taiyuan is exceptionally capable."

I was more than a little surprised. I hadn't realized you could look at it that way.

Everything came down to a cold calculation of profit and loss. Now I understood exactly what Wolhwa meant when she called herself a merchant.

Knowing that someone like her was on our side was reassuring.

But…

"You're overlooking one important thing. If I'm innocent, who actually poisoned Lee Seogeun?"

That was the heart of the war—the largest piece of the puzzle, and one Wolhwa had failed to find.

If the Lower District Sect had discovered the culprit's identity, she would have brought that information today.

Wolhwa sighed.

“I’m ashamed to say we haven’t uncovered anything yet. But our sect is doing everything it can. Ah, we’re almost there.”

There were still plenty of things I wanted to ask, but I had no choice but to fall silent when I noticed the approaching gate guards.

Our alliance with the Lower District Sect is still a secret.

A four-horse carriage, apparently the one Wolhwa had arrived in, came into view. The gate guards stood in a wide circle around it, and even from here, I could feel the strange tension in the air.

Did something happen?

I channeled internal energy into my eyes and ears. My enhanced senses soon picked up the gate guards’ tense voices.

“He’s a master. No doubt about it. At least Supreme First Rate, perhaps even Peak. See the whip at his waist? He must wield it like a ghost.”

“A master of that caliber volunteering to serve as a coachman? I suppose a peerless beauty really is something else.”

The martial artists speaking to each other sounded fairly experienced, and their voices were deadly serious. A younger martial artist cautiously murmured:

“But if he’s that skilled, doesn’t his posture have too many openings? And he’s so thin…”

The senior martial artists clicked their tongues.

“Kid, this fellow and I have ten years of experience at the gate-watch office. We can tell from a person’s eyes alone. What the hell would a little shit like you know, butting into your elders’ conversation?”

“Tsk. Openings? Those look like openings to you? Can’t you see the composure and natural ease that only true masters possess?”

“Then what about his temples? Masters with profound internal energy have bulging temples.”

“That’s just Returning to Simplicity…”

Unfortunately, the conversation ended there. The gate guards noticed us standing blankly in front of the main gate and scattered.

Thanks to them, I learned the identity of the Peak master who wielded a whip like a ghost—the romantic martial artist who had volunteered to become a coachman after falling for Wolhwa’s beauty.

“Young Master, do you remember me?”

“…”

As if I could forget.

That deep voice. Those sharp eyes, practically radiating the aura of a master.

It was the coachman who had brought me to the Jin Family of Taiyuan a few days ago.

I never expected to see him here. As I stood there speechless, Wolhwa spoke up.

“I hear the two of you are acquainted. Last time, you passed through life and death together and formed a deep friendship that transcended age and status…”

No. That’s not what happened. Please stop.

I tugged at Wolhwa’s sleeve, but it was already too late. The coachman smiled gently and opened his mouth.

“Even now, whenever I close my eyes, the memories of that day remain vivid. The Heavenly Axe… He was truly a formidable bastard.”

The gate guards, who had been listening intently, exclaimed.

“Oh!”

“The Heavenly Axe… Surely he means that Heavenly Axe from the Eighteen Strongholds of Green Forest?”

“Wasn’t he an infamous Peak master of Green Forest? To kill a man like that, this gentleman must be…”

“…”

They seemed to have gotten something seriously wrong.

I had no idea where to begin correcting them—or where to stop.

As I stood there blankly, the coachman suddenly pulled me into a hug.

“If not for you, Young Master, I would have been in serious trouble.”

This man had a strange way of putting things. Without me, he would’ve been drinking a cup of makgeolli[75] at the summit of Mount Beimang[76] by now.

“Could you let go of me first? Then we can talk…”

I was just about to pry him off when someone muttered:

“Yama Whip.[77] The master of the whip arts who vanished without a trace more than ten years ago. It’s him. It has to be.”

A ripple passed through the gate guards.

“Yama Whip? You mean that Peak master who traveled the realm beating down remnants of the Demonic Path?”

“I’ve heard that name too. A master who stood between the orthodox and unorthodox paths, with no known sect or past… Come to think of it, didn’t his trail disappear somewhere near Shanxi?”

“Then the Third Young Master—no, our Young Master—is acquainted with Great Hero Yama Whip.”

“And that’s not all. He must have played a major role in taking down the Heavenly Axe.”

“Oh! Ohhh!”

---

[75] Makgeolli is a cloudy Korean rice wine.

[76] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds and is commonly invoked as a destination for the dead.

[77] Yama is a Buddhist lord of the underworld associated with judgment of the dead.

Hot, admiring gazes poured in from every direction. Perhaps realizing that something was wrong, the coachman tried to pull away, but my hand clamped firmly around his shoulder.

“Young Master?”

I gave him the brightest smile in the world.

“To meet you again like this—Yama. Whip. Great Hero!”

My words were oil thrown onto a fire.

“Woooah!”

The excited gate guards stomped their feet, while Wolhwa doubled over, desperately trying to hold back her laughter.

Ding.

SYSTEM

- **Rumors about the Poisoner are dying down!**
- **Rumors about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi are gaining credibility!**
- **Fame increases by 20!**
- **Passionate supporters have appeared!**

As the beautiful System notifications rang out, a famous saying came to mind.

The perfect lie… is a true story.

The young man stared at the ceiling with his eyes wide open. The light had gone out of his once-bright black eyes, and his face was twisted with fear and pain.

“Seogeun. My son.”

A large, rough hand caressed the young man’s face. The intense poisonous energy that had seeped in through the skin was stopped by internal energy that surged up instinctively.

“How did this happen to you?”

The middle-aged man’s voice was thick with grief.

He had grown up a complete orphan and spent decades in Murim.

He had met countless people and watched just as many leave. From his days as a green twenty-year-old wandering martial artist to the moment he became the master of a sect, he had accumulated more memories than he could count.

“Did it hurt? Were you so bitter that you couldn’t even close your eyes?”

He gazed down at his son’s wide-open eyes. Every blood vessel had burst, staining them red.

His son had barely reached twenty. Bloody tears flowed from the eyes of the father standing before his poisoned child.

“My son.”

The poisonous energy that had entered through his hand was spreading throughout his body. Within only a few breaths, his head began to spin and his limbs went numb.

Such a deadly poison.

He could vividly picture his son’s final moments—his entire body locked rigid, unable even to struggle.

“I will remember this pain.”

The next moment, immense internal energy rose like wildfire and drove back the poison. The poison consuming his insides vanished in an instant, as though torn apart by a pack of hundreds of wolves.

“I will repay them a hundredfold. A thousandfold.”

The Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek, left his son’s corpse behind and walked away.

When he opened the pavilion door, he saw the black night sky and the torches flickering beneath it.

Around two hundred fully armed men stood outside. The man at their head bowed.

“Father.”

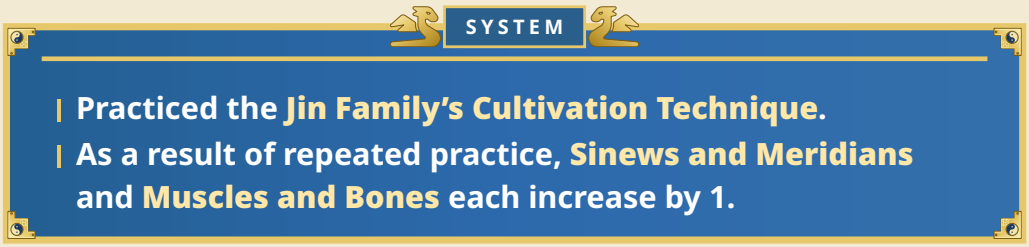
Lee Cheonbaek nodded to his eldest son.

“Go. Tonight… our revenge begins.”

That night, around two hundred martial artists departed the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Chapter 21

Ding.



"Whew."

I opened my eyes with a deep exhale. In the predawn gloom, the candlelit room shimmered amber.

Failed again.

My fist clenched in the silence.

How many attempts had that been? Twenty? Thirty? The result was what mattered. Once again, I had failed to draw out the hardened mass of internal energy.

Should I take comfort in the fact that I'm getting better?

I was gradually getting used to handling internal energy. If I had been a C-rank Hunter instead of an F-rank—or at least a D-rank—I would have adapted much faster. But reality was cold and unforgiving.

The steady improvement in my Muscles and Bones and Sinews and Meridians must be helping too.

Internal energy flowed through the body's meridians. The more I practiced my cultivation technique and improved those two attributes, the wider and sturdier the pathways became. Compared to when I had started, I could circulate far more internal energy at a much faster speed.

It's all thanks to the Skill Points.

The ten Skill Points awarded with every level-up were doing their job. Nothing nourished my Muscles and Bones and Sinews and Meridians better.

Open Skill Window.

SYSTEM

Skill Window
Lv. 17 Jin Taekyung
Cultivation Technique: Jin Family's Cultivation Technique (Fourth Stage)
Martial Arts: Jin Family's Spear Technique (Fifth Stage) / Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique (Fifth Stage)
Muscles and Bones: 105
Remaining Points: 0

I can see a chance.

The impregnable fortress was gradually shrinking and growing flimsier. If I kept hammering away at it, I felt as though the gate would soon open.

Fortunately, I might lack talent, but I had persistence.

I'll keep trying until it works.

I was about to sit cross-legged again and circulate my qi when my senses, sharpened by the many earlier attempts, picked up an unusual sound.

This is…

A low, droning hum. At first, it sounded like a swarm of bees, but it was actually the murmur of many people.

What's going on?

I channeled internal energy into my ears. Perhaps because of the distance, it still wasn't nearly enough to make out everything clearly.

But it was enough.

One word stood out among the indistinct voices.

Battle!

The Mount Heng Sword Sect. The battle had finally begun.

I hurriedly uncrossed my legs and sprang to my feet. Then I leaped through the half-open window.

I landed like a cat. Before me, lights came on across the pavilions one by one.

So, in the end…

It had begun.

Twenty-five.

That was the number of corpses laid out in orderly rows.

When I saw them lying there like dead trees, every trace of life gone, I was left speechless.

"This is…"

I was a Hunter. I had fought countless battles and witnessed countless deaths.

Poisoned, cut apart, crushed, blown to pieces…

The manner of death varied wildly depending on the monster involved. But all those deaths had one thing in common.

Every victim had been an adult.

Adulthood was one of the basic conditions for awakening. No one knew what the exact standard was or why it existed. It was simply a rule accepted as naturally as the existence of Gates.

That was why none of the countless deaths I had witnessed had ever involved a child.

This is a game. It's just a game.

I kept repeating the words to myself. But the sight before me was too horrific to dismiss so easily.

BLOOD

The character had been carved into their foreheads. Torchlight reflected off the dried blood.

More than ten children had gone cold like that.

The oldest could not have been more than middle-school age. Some looked even younger.

Every single one of them was dead.

"Urgh!"

One of the martial artists holding a torch in a trembling hand doubled over. Soon, the sound of retching rang out from all around us.

Then a hand reached down and picked up the torch he had dropped.

"Somi. Yes, that was her name. On the day I became acting Family Head, the Branch Leader of Eung-hyeon bragged about her until his mouth ran dry, calling her his treasure."

It was Jin Wikyung. His eyes dim and lifeless, he raised the torch and shone it over the children's faces.

One by one.

Each time another face was revealed, he spoke the child's name without fail.

After naming the last child, Jin Wikyung looked at me.

"Do you know who these children are?"

"…No."

"They were members of our family sent to the branches in Eung-hyeon, Saneum, and Sakju."

I didn't know where those places were. But I could guess what fate the children's parents had met.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect's intentions made me sick.

Fucking psychotic bastards.

Look. We can slaughter even children this young. Soon, you'll end up the same way.

I could almost hear the voice of the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, a man whose face I had never even seen.

"This is all my fault. Even children who knew no martial arts were slaughtered so cruelly…"

Jin Wikyung was blaming himself in a trembling voice when—

"That is the essence of war, Lesser Family Head."

The Head Elder appeared, stroking his silver beard. His gaze remained calm as it swept over the corpses.

"Victory and defeat—neither comes without death. The Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect… Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek, was it? As one would expect of a former wandering martial artist, he understands war well. These children alone make that clear."

The casual way he said it sent a chill through me.

What the hell is wrong with this AI?

This NPC was missing something. That made him seem all the more dangerous.

I kept my mouth shut. Jin Wikyung's face twisted as he spoke.

"…Please choose your words carefully. They are members of our family."

"No. Those children are casualties of war. Countless more will die from now on. Perhaps even at this very moment."

"Head Elder. I told you to watch your words."

Jin Wikyung growled. Had we been alone, he would have been ready to start something right then and there.

But the Head Elder remained calm.

"Did you not anticipate this?"

He had suddenly switched to informal speech, yet it came so naturally that neither Jin Wikyung nor I even registered the change.

"Saneum, Eung-hyeon, Sakju. All three lay within the Mount Heng Sword Sect's reach. When you sent messenger pigeons to each branch the day before, did you truly never consider that something like this might happen?"

"That…"

"You knew harm would come to them. Sending those pigeons was nothing more than a way to ease your conscience."

"Enough. Please, enough."

"It was an excellent decision. If you had tried to save the branches, you would have had to run for seven days and nights without rest, then fight the enemy while utterly exhausted. Isn't that right?"

Jin Wikyung stared at the Head Elder with a pale face. Fresh blood flowed between his tightly clenched fingers.

"I—I…"

"Everything comes with a sacrifice. Look at the bigger picture. You are the Lesser Family Head responsible for the hundreds of family members of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Jin Wikyung's body trembled. The anger and sorrow drained from his face, leaving behind a strange emptiness.

"Sacrifice…"

"The war has only just begun. Isn't that so, Lesser Family Head?"

The Head Elder offered a fist-and-palm salute.[78] I bit down hard on my lip.

What an impossible old man to figure out.

The Head Elder was clearly dangerous. His position in the family, his utterly unreadable motives, even the psychopathic way he could look at the corpses of children without twitching an eyebrow…

But…

He's right.

From my perspective, Jin Wikyung was a good Lesser Family Head. He was deeply humane and sharp-minded.

But the moment he saw the corpses, he had been shaken more than anyone. Without the Head Elder's cold rebuke, it would have taken him a long time to regain his composure.

He helped him. The Head Elder, of all people…

Are they enemies in peacetime but united during war?

If so, that's a relief.

I was looking at the Head Elder with a mixture of suspicion and relief when he spoke.

"So the Third Young Master is here as well."

My heart dropped at the sight of those shrewd gray eyes. It was the first time the Head Elder had spoken to me.

"Greetings, Head Elder."

I did my best to hide my surprise, but the Head Elder regarded me with a strange smile.

"I've been hearing an interesting rumor within the family lately. Something about… the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

I never expected to hear that ridiculous nickname from the Head Elder.

[78] A fist-and-palm salute is a traditional martial greeting made by bringing a closed fist and an open palm together.

“I’ve also heard that you are acquainted with Yama Whip.[79] They say you joined forces with him to defeat the Heavenly Axe.”

“Cough. Cough.”

“Are you ill?”

“N-no. I’m just feeling a little chilly.”

“Oh dear. That won’t do for someone who is about to accomplish great things.”

My awkward smile slowly froze.

“What do you mean?”

“Someone capable of helping eliminate a formidable fiend like the Heavenly Axe is a valuable asset in battle. Surely that rumor isn’t false.”

“…”

“Therefore, as a direct-line member of our family, I believe it is only natural that you fight at the forefront. What do you think, Lesser Family Head?”

The Head Elder smiled faintly. Jin Wikyung stared at that smile for a moment, then asked me, “What do you think?”

Checkmate.

The moment the word came to mind, a familiar notification rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Mission
You have been appointed captain of a White Tiger Hall reconnaissance squad.
From now on, lead the subordinates assigned to you on missions and build merit!
Grade: Repeatable Quest
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Earn 100 Merit Points (0 / 100)
Reward: Changes according to the degree of success.
Failure: Changes according to the degree of failure.

I closed the Quest Window. I had already seen it several times, and besides, the White Tiger Hall martial artist who had stepped away earlier had just returned.

“These are the supplies issued to captains.”

A sword.

[79] Yama is the lord of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

A black martial uniform with a crude white tiger embroidered on it.

And a smooth wooden plaque that smelled strongly of fresh wood.

That was everything.

“The newly assigned members are waiting at the reconnaissance squad’s quarters. The location is…”

Fortunately, I knew the place. A pavilion I had passed several times had been assigned as the reconnaissance squad’s quarters.

After leaving White Tiger Hall, I first ducked into an empty alley.

Open Inventory.

Ten seconds was enough to put on the entire uniform. I changed clothes, shoved the sword deep into my Inventory, then pulled out the *Sharp Spear*.

Until now, I had thoroughly enjoyed the privileges of being the Third Young Master in a lavish private pavilion.

But things were different from here on out.

It’s communal living, right?

We would eat together and sleep together. I couldn’t exactly perform the magic trick of making a two-meter[80] iron spear pop out of thin air whenever I needed it.

Once I hung the wooden plaque engraved with *Captain* at my waist, I felt like I’d become Ordinary Martial Artist #1 of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Not just an ordinary martial artist. I’m a reconnaissance squad captain.

Captain of a White Tiger Hall reconnaissance squad.

I had never expected to receive a position like this.

Of course, there had been some fierce disagreement over it. The Head Elder wanted to place me in a combat unit aligned with the Council of Elders, while Jin Wikyung had vehemently opposed him.

In the end, they compromised.

I would serve as a reconnaissance captain, a position whose duties were not especially difficult—but under the command of the White Tiger Hall Master, who belonged to the Council of Elders’ faction.

Before I knew what was happening, the position was mine.

I never imagined this was how I’d get dragged into the war.

I could have just told them to do whatever the hell they wanted, but I held back. The first reason was the Head Elder’s eyes, which flashed every time Yama Whip was mentioned.

The second reason was…

The children.

It’s a game. It’s all graphics, nothing more than an illusion.

[80] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.

No matter how many times I repeated that to myself, the corpses and the character carved into their foreheads kept flickering before my eyes.

Part of my decision had been emotional.

This wasn't good.

Don't get too invested. I can't confuse reality with the game.

Things like this had been happening more and more often lately. At first, I had treated the NPCs like people for fun. But these days, I was actually thinking of them as real people and forming relationships with them.

Every time I caught myself doing it, I was startled.

Maybe it was a side effect of playing the game for too long.

"Is this it?"

Before I knew it, I had reached the reconnaissance squad's quarters. My mouth fell open.

Cracked wood and a musty smell.

Good lord, there was even a beehive under the eaves. I had never seen one that big before.

Just like a company that treats you like family…

Look at those benefits.

Or maybe this was a mean-spirited prank by the White Tiger Hall Master, who disliked me. Perhaps he couldn't openly give me grief yet, so this was his way of telling me to eat shit.

All right. Let's give it a shot.

I took a deep breath, opened the door, and stepped inside.

Creeeak.

The old floor wailed beneath my foot, the sound especially ominous.

Chapter 22

The smell of mold hit me the moment I stepped into the room. The place reminded me of an army barracks, and the members of the reconnaissance squad were waiting inside.

Ten people.

I activated Qi Sense and looked them over.

As my gaze passed from one unfamiliar face to the next, Level displays popped into view.

Level 14. Level 15. Level 14…

Most of them were around the same level. Then I reached the ninth man.

The number jumped sharply. His face was familiar, too.

Hyuk Mujin?

It was the same Hyuk Mujin who had picked a fight with me when I first arrived at the Jin Family of Taiyuan a few days ago. When our eyes met, his lips curled into a smirk.

“What a pleasure to see you again, Third. Young. Master.”

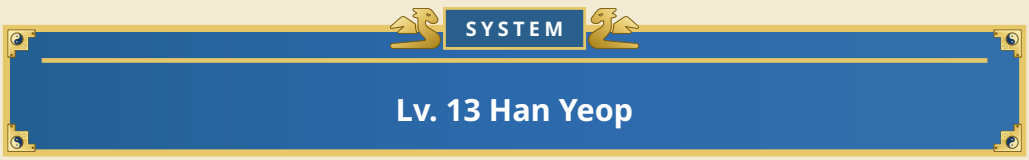
I stared at his openly hostile smile.

“From now on, call me Squad Leader.”

“…As you wish.”

Ignoring Hyuk Mujin’s piercing stare, I turned to the tenth member of the reconnaissance squad. The young man who had been beaming ever since I arrived shot to his feet.

“Young Master—no, Squad Leader! I look forward to serving under you.”



It seemed the war had forced some people into new assignments. The White Tiger Hall clerk I’d met earlier had said the reconnaissance squads were made up of martial artists drawn from several different posts.

Hyuk Mujin originally belonged to the Gate Guard Pavilion, too.

Maybe that was why the atmosphere in the room felt so unsettled.

The squad members watched me with a mixture of awkwardness toward the strangers around them, anxiety about the war, and a hint of anticipation.

I spoke first.

“I’m Jin Taekyung, the newly appointed leader of this White Tiger Hall reconnaissance squad. I look forward to working with you.”

Clap, clap, clap.

Someone’s lonely applause died out within a few seconds, and Han Yeop lowered his hand with an embarrassed expression.

The atmosphere was even stiffer than I’d expected.

But that’s not necessarily a bad thing.

We were at war. It was better for them to stay tense than to laugh and socialize like we were all here to make friends.

Of course, too much tension could become poisonous. Easing it at the right time was also part of my job as squad leader.

That much, I’m used to.

Newbie Hunters froze the moment they entered a Gate for the first time. Real combat was different from practice. Everything they had learned and trained for at the Hunter training center flew off into outer space, and they were overwhelmed by the primal scent of death.

That was why Guild veterans helped the rookies keep their heads together. I’d been one of those veterans.

Though I was assigned exclusively to F-ranks.

The power levels were similar, too. From what I’d seen, a second-rate martial artist in Murim fell somewhere between an E-rank and an F-rank Hunter.

In other words, I was now leading a ten-man F-rank party. I’d never actually been a party leader, but I’d watched other people do the job until I was sick of it.

“Anyone with combat experience, raise your hand.”

At the abrupt question, every member of the reconnaissance squad raised a hand. They all looked confused.

“Keep it raised if you’ve fought at least five times.”

Half the hands went down. Han Yeop’s was among them.

Five people with experience in at least five battles. That wasn’t bad. In fact, it was better than I’d expected.

But the most important question remained.

“Keep it raised if you’ve killed someone.”

Four hands dropped weakly. I looked at the only member of the reconnaissance squad who still had his hand raised.

"How many?"

He snorted.

"Five. It was during last year's bandit suppression campaign. One of them was a Deputy Stronghold Lord. He was a pretty strong bastard—"

I cut him off before he could continue.

"Good. You're the deputy squad leader from now on."

Hyuk Mujin's mouth, which had been preparing to ramble on, snapped shut.

"Deputy squad leader?"

"Yeah. Speak up now if you don't like it."

In a group full of rookies, experience mattered more than anything.

Hyuk Mujin was the only one who could swing a weapon at the enemy without hesitation.

Black cat, white cat.

White cat, black cat, even an ill-mannered cat—it didn't matter as long as it caught mice.

Hyuk Mujin considered it with a conflicted expression before answering.

"…Hmph. If it's an order, I suppose I have no choice."

He sure had a difficult way of saying he wanted to be deputy squad leader.

"Then Hyuk Mujin is the deputy squad leader. From now on, you're Number One."

"Number One? What's that supposed to mean?"

"It's your designation. From now on, everyone in the reconnaissance squad goes by number instead of name. Hyuk Mujin is Number One. Next, you sitting over there. Yes, you. You're Number Two."

I went around the room, assigning everyone a number from One to Ten.

Hyuk Mujin frowned.

"Why are you doing this?"

"Because it's convenient. We might end up fighting today. Do you want to spend the whole day memorizing names?"

"That's—"

"Then do as you're told. It's an order."

Hyuk Mujin glared at me, his expression rigid, but I didn't look away.

Part of me even hoped he would act as insolent as he had the last time. We could end up in battle within a few days, and his current attitude would be a problem.

If he challenged me, I would have to show him the difference in our strength.

Clearly.

"…I'll follow your orders."

"What was that?"

"Number One. I said I'm Number One."

His voice trembled as he answered. He was more perceptive than I'd expected. Maybe it had something to do with the rumors about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

What mattered was that Hyuk Mujin had fallen in line.

Keeping my expression neutral, I continued.

"What I'm about to say may sound strange and unfamiliar. But bear with it. It's better than getting stabbed to death, isn't it? Don't you agree?"

The other squad members weren't as open about their displeasure as Hyuk Mujin, but they still watched me anxiously.

All except one.

"I'll do whatever the Squad Leader says!"

Han Yeop shouted like a fangirl. The only difference was that he had a spear in his hand instead of an idol light stick.

Oh, right.

I grinned at the squad.

"Now, anyone who uses a sword, raise your hand."

The core of party hunting was assigning positions.

Raid tactics in the real world had been standardized into manuals long ago.

Three tanks. Four damage dealers. Two mages and one healer. For a ten-person party, that was the ideal combination.

Obviously, there aren't any mages or healers here.

I had to balance the party as well as I could using only tanks and damage dealers, but—

"…You're telling me no one knows how to use a shield?"

My voice trembled at the horrifying discovery.

Good lord. I had ten damage dealers. Nine used swords, and Han Yeop was the only one with a spear.

What kind of horrifying monoculture is this?

A mixed breed would be better. At least that would have a little of everything.

Hyuk Mujin looked as if he couldn't understand what the problem was.

"A man ought to wield a sword."

The sight of everyone else nodding along left me speechless.

You're too well-fed. Way too well-fed.

Try slamming your head into a pool of blood and see if you still talk like that.

Sword? Spear? There was no such distinction. You bashed people with whatever rock you happened to grab, threw dirt, climbed on top of them, and bit them with your teeth.

When your life was on the line, anything within reach became both a weapon and a lifeline.

These people, who had only ever fought bandits at best, still didn't understand that.

Do I need to start training them tomorrow?

Not for their sake. For my own survival.

Even teaching them a few tricks would make a real difference in a melee.

I worked like a dog for seven years. I'm not dying because of a bunch of rookies.

That was when it happened.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

A large bell tolled three times.

Since individuals here had no way to tell the exact time, bells rang at set hours. The three tolls marked Mi-si, roughly one to three in the afternoon.

And—

"Get ready. This is our first deployment."

They also signaled the reconnaissance squad's first mission.

"He should be doing fine."

Jin Wikyung looked up at Wipeng's abrupt comment. Until that moment, he had been staring blankly at a cooling cup of tea.

"What are you talking about?"

"The Third Young Master."

A full day had passed since the reconnaissance squad led by Jin Taekyung departed from the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Their mission was to scout the nearby county towns.

"They left around noon yesterday, so they should arrive within two days."

"Ah. Taekyung."

Jin Wikyung gave a weary chuckle.

"I wondered what you meant. Never mind."

"Never mind?"

"How long are you going to treat him like a child? He's a grown man now. I'm sure he'll manage on his own."

"…I'm beginning to doubt my ears."

"I did coddle him quite a bit. He was much younger back then."

"I agree, to some extent. He's changed considerably in the past few days."

"Heroes grow by overcoming adversity."

"…"

"Anyway, I can stop worrying about the youngest now. I'll be able to focus more on the main family."

"You should rest for a while. You look exhausted."

"Wipeng. Members of our family have died."

Sorrow and resolve weighed on his voice. Wipeng fell silent, and Jin Wikyung returned to his work.

But the silence lasted only two hours.

"What is that…?"

A black speck in the sky drew closer. Spreading its enormous wings, a messenger eagle landed on the office windowsill.

It belonged to the Lower District Sect.

Jin Wikyung sprang to his feet and opened the tube fastened to the eagle's leg. When he unfolded the letter, he found a message written in tiny characters.

> Jopil, One Question, One Kill, has appeared in Jeongyang with a special detachment of twenty men.

"Jeongyang…!"

Beyond Jeongyang lay Honju. Beyond Honju lay Taiyuan. Special detachment or not, he hadn't expected them to cover hundreds of li[81] in only a few days.

And that wasn't all.

There were still family members from the branches who had not returned to the main family. What if the enemy was tracking them?

Every moment counts.

It didn't take Jin Wikyung long to decide.

"Select fifty martial artists immediately and send them to Jeongyang. One Question, One Kill Jopil is a brutal Peak master. Bring our family members—"

The children came to mind.

Their small limbs. Their faces twisted in pain. Their vacant eyes.

Jin Wikyung clenched his teeth.

"Bring our family members home safely."

"My lord."

[81] A Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi).

Wipeng’s expression had hardened. Jin Wikyung stared blankly at him, as though a thought had seized him, before speaking.

“Taekyung. Where did you say Taekyung went?”

His voice came out strained.

“…Jeongyang.”

Chapter 23

The Jin Family of Taiyuan.

As its name suggests, its headquarters were in Taiyuan. But like a conglomerate in the real world, the Jin Family of Taiyuan's influence was not limited to a single city.

The family had been established two hundred years ago and had long since expanded its sphere of influence by setting up branches in county towns throughout Shanxi Province.

Scout the area near Jeongyang and return within five days.

That was the reconnaissance squad's first mission. The squad members' reactions to the order fell into two camps.

"Doesn't sound like much."

Some, like Hyuk Mujin, were disappointed. Others, like Han Yeop, sighed in relief.

Of course, neither reaction pleased me.

Hyuk Mujin was consumed by a pointless hunger for glory, while Han Yeop was afraid to fight.

Still, a safe mission is probably for the best.

The thought of running into the enemy with these guys was horrifying. I'd be safer fighting on the front lines with people I could trust.

Should I apply for a transfer?

Suppressing a sigh, I raised my fist. It was one of the hand signals I had taught them earlier. It meant stop.

Snort.

The eleven horses trotting at a steady pace came to a halt with a chorus of snorts. Hyuk Mujin, riding to my right, spoke irritably.

"Why are we stopping?"

"Rest."

"Again?"

"Two hours of travel, fifteen minutes of rest. Didn't I tell you that already?"

"I can keep going!"

"Then go by yourself."

I jerked my chin toward the rear. The other squad members were breathing hard. Traveling on horseback was faster than going on foot, but it also consumed a considerable amount of stamina.

Hyuk Mujin's much higher Level allowed him to hold up fairly well, but fatigue was building in the others.

"When I tell you to rest, you rest. That's an order."

Ignoring Hyuk Mujin's scowl, I addressed the squad.

"Fifteen minutes of rest."

They had been given fifteen minutes to rest, but the reconnaissance squad members didn't look particularly happy. That was because I immediately pulled out a large leather backpack.

I reached inside and thought,

Open Inventory.

With a clatter, three shields materialized inside the backpack.

They were wooden shields plated with iron, taken from the armory before we left the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Light and sturdy, they were perfectly serviceable.

"Number Seven. Number Eight. Number Nine."

The three designated squad members accepted the shields with doomed expressions.

They were the tanks I had selected by force.

Seven damage dealers. Three tanks. And me.

It was a party composition that would be wiped out the moment it entered a Gate, but for now, I had to make do.

"Everyone to your positions."

Next came formation drills.

"Basic formation."

The three shield bearers formed the front line. Six swordsmen, from Number One Hyuk Mujin through Number Six, made up the second. Han Yeop and I took the rear.

It was a formation focused on threats from the front.

"Spread out. Scatter and assemble. Disperse."

Their faces were still full of complaints, but by now they followed the commands with reasonable skill. They were much better than F-rank Hunters fresh out of a Hunter training center.

These NPCs are better than real people.

The difference probably came down to whether they could use internal energy.

Unlike F-rank Hunters, who couldn't manipulate mana at all, Murim's NPCs could use internal energy, however faintly.

They were simply low-Level and inexperienced.

I moved on to the final stage of formation training.

"All-out retreat."

The reconnaissance squad members hesitated.

"What?"

"What does 'all-out retreat' mean?"

“Exactly what it sounds like. Retreat with everything you’ve got.”

“Then what formation should we—?”

“If it comes to that, formation won’t matter. Just run as fast as you can. Don’t look back, and scatter as widely as possible.”

“Heh. You call that an order?”

The mocking voice belonged, naturally, to Hyuk Mujin.

“I can’t stand this anymore. Third Young Master, do you think war is some children’s game? If you want to make nonsense sound convincing, you should at least read a military strategy manual first.”

“A military strategy manual?”

“Yes, a military strategy manual! Retreating in good order is one of the most basic principles of warfare. What kind of nonsense are you spouting?”

Hyuk Mujin’s open defiance drew hesitant murmurs from the other squad members.

“He’s not wrong.”

“We aren’t government troops. Why are we drilling formations and being forced to carry shields…?”

“I’ve never even heard of an all-out retreat.”

See? Everyone agrees with me.

That was what Hyuk Mujin’s smug face seemed to say.

Then Han Yeop cut in, his voice wavering.

“I-I don’t agree.”

“What?”

“The Third Young Master—I mean, the Captain—must have a reason for doing this… right?”

“A reason?”

Hyuk Mujin glared at him.

“What reason could there be? The Third Young Master spent his youth drinking with women instead of training. He caused every kind of trouble despite being like that. And that’s not all. He was also the one who caused this war—”

“Enough.”

Hyuk Mujin flinched when I cut him off. He seemed to realize that he had misspoken.

But some people were like that. When they needed to back down, they took another step forward instead.

“Wasn’t the Third Young Master the one who caused this war?”

Hyuk Mujin was too proud to stop himself.

Once the words were out, a chilly silence descended.

Gulp.

Someone’s throat bobbed loudly. Nine pairs of eyes turned toward Hyuk Mujin and me.

“D-do you have something to say?”

Something to say? Of course I did.

“Everyone gets another fifteen minutes of rest.”

At the same time, I slapped Hyuk Mujin across the face with an open palm.

Smack!

“One.”

His jaw twisted to the side. It was an ordinary slap, without even a trace of internal energy. His face was still dazed by the sudden turn of events when I struck him a second time.

“What the—!”

He wasn’t completely helpless, at least. He raised an arm to block.

What he had failed to account for was the difference in our strength.

Smack!

“Two.”

Hyuk Mujin’s upper body slammed into the ground. He sprang back up, my palm print stamped on one cheek like a tattoo.

It didn’t take long for his bewilderment to turn into rage.

“You fucking bastard!”

He was properly furious now. As he charged at me, eyes bulging, I hooked his leg and sent him sprawling. At the same time, I put some strength into my left hand and struck him.

Smack.

“Three.”

“Urgh.”

His legs nearly gave out, and he staggered. Three consecutive blows with that much force were bound to rattle his brain.

“What, are you saving your internal energy to make soup?”

That got through to him. Strength returned to his wavering legs, and internal energy surged through his body. He glared at me with venomous eyes.

“You’ll regret this.”

“I doubt it.”

I caught the fist flying toward my face.

Speed, strength, timing.

I could see it all. Compared to Lee Seogeun, Hyuk Mujin was nowhere close.

“Four.”

His head snapped back. Thick droplets of blood sprayed through the air in slow motion. His pupils had lost focus, and his legs hung limp.

Yet somehow, he didn't fall. He couldn't—not unless I let go of his fist.

"Five."

Smack!

That was his limit. Hyuk Mujin finally lost consciousness. As he sprawled on the ground in a bizarre pose, something landed on his body with a soft patter.

Snow?

I looked up. The winter sky was showering us with tiny white scraps of garbage.

"Break's over. We're leaving."

I tossed out the words and turned away. Behind me, the reconnaissance squad members finally released the breaths they had been holding.

When Hyuk Mujin woke two hours later, the first thing he did was charge at me.

"You fucking—!"

Smack. Thud.

"Move him."

"Y-yes, sir!"

Another crisp slap knocked him out again, and the other squad members dragged him into a corner of the cabin.

A cabin. We got lucky.

According to one squad member who knew the surrounding area well, we should have reached Jeongyang before sunset at the latest.

But there was nothing we could do about the sudden blizzard, and this cabin was the only shelter we had managed to find.

Apparently, it was a hunters' shelter known only to people familiar with the area.

It's ridiculously small, but I'll take it.

The mission might be delayed, but this was a hundred times better than trudging through the snow all night, collapsing from exhaustion, and then running into the enemy.

That was when—

"C-Captain."

It was Han Yeop. Behind him, the other squad members stole glances at me, gauging my mood.

"What should we do now?"

"Hm? Sleep."

"N-no, that's not what I meant…"

Watching them fidget, a thought struck me.

Don't tell me…

"Do you want to train?"

Nod, nod.

Look at those heads bobbing furiously. Look at those eyes burning with enthusiasm.

Seeing is believing, my ass. One beating beats a hundred explanations.

Beating them once really was better than explaining something a hundred times.

It was around noon.

Sunlight flashed off a sword blade. That was all the martial artist saw.

"Urgh."

Thud.

His knees buckled, and his face slammed into the frozen ground.

Blood poured from the gaping wound running from his shoulder to his chest. It was beyond recovery. The martial artist knew he was going to die.

"The others… Please, let them live."

His fading voice cut off abruptly. A middle-aged man clicked his tongue as he stared into the martial artist's wide-open eyes.

"Good grief, you poor fool."

How could he charge in like that without warning? The words that followed never reached the dead man. The fifty-odd wandering martial artists surrounding them snickered.

"Of all people, he had to run into the boss. Rotten luck."

"Only an orthodox-faction bastard would keep playing the hero to the bitter end. What should we do, Boss?"

Their gleaming eyes turned toward the survivors, a group of six or seven women and children.

"Great Hero, please spare the children."

At the plea from the oldest-looking woman, the middle-aged man—Jopil, One Question, One Kill—smiled gently.

"I'm sorry, but what can I do? I'm no Great Hero."

"But you're still human. How can you kill children who can't even tell right from wrong?"

"Hah. You have quite a bit of spirit for a woman. Wait. I heard the Sakju Branch Leader's family survived. Could you be…?"

"He is my husband."

“Ah, I thought so. I never imagined such a pathetic man could have such a virtuous wife.”

Jopil smiled, and the woman’s expression hardened.

“You never intended to spare us.”

“Rest easy. Raping women before I kill them isn’t one of my hobbies.”

“The children…”

“This is a harsh world. How are little ones supposed to survive without their mother?”

“You’re worse than a beast.”

“Last words noted.”

That was the signal.

Swordlight flashed, and screams rang out.

A short while later, the blood-soaked wandering martial artists tossed the corpses into the mountain thickets.

“Only the wild animals will feast tonight.”

The man with the tiny birdlike eyes muttered. He was Jopil’s right-hand man, a first-rate wandering martial artist known by the nickname Black Mountain Blade.

“We should feast, too. If we finish this job properly, what’s a mere thousand pieces of gold?”

Jopil laughed in delight. The payment for this job would be enormous, but more than that, he was enjoying the situation itself.

“I never imagined the day would come when we’d hunt the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

His filthy leather shoe came down on the fallen martial artist’s corpse.

The martial artist had belonged to the Sakju Branch, one of the ten or so branches of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“Was that the last one?”

“No, Boss.”

“They slip away like rats. How many?”

“Three in total. One martial artist and two children. They passed through Jeongyang only a few hours ago and are headed for Honju.”

“That’s troublesome. It’ll take half a day.”

“There’s no need for you to go yourself. I’ll take care of it.”

“Will you?”

A pleased smile spread across Jopil’s lips.

“Good. Take half the men. You have half a day. How does that sound?”

There was only one possible answer. Black Mountain Blade bowed deeply.

Chapter 24

He ran. It was the only thing he could do.

Even as his father and the people of the Sakju Branch—people who had been like family to him—died one after another, there was only one thing a fourteen-year-old boy could do.

Run.

"Oppa,[82] I'm cold."

His little sister whimpered in his arms. The boy, Socheon, blew warm breath over her hands, stiff with cold.

"We're almost there. Just hold on a little longer, okay?"

"When are we going home? Soyul wants to see Mom…"

"She came yesterday, too."

"You're lying. Did you see her?"

"Of course I did."

In my dream.

Socheon swallowed the rest of the sentence.

His mother had appeared in his dream the night before, exactly as she had three days earlier. She had spent a long time stroking and gazing at Soyul, who had fallen asleep from exhaustion, before speaking.

"Survive. You must survive."

Her voice still rang in his ears, and the sight of her back as she led the others away still hovered before his eyes.

What happened to Mother? Could she have…? No. That can't be.

It was then, as he struggled to suppress his ominous feelings, that he heard something.

Rustle.

"Who's there?"

The motion came naturally. He pulled his little sister close and drew the dagger concealed inside his clothes.

After the night his home had burned and he had witnessed countless deaths, the once-cheerful boy had acquired the eyes of a wild beast.

"I'll count to three. One, two…"

"It's me."

The dagger slowly lowered when a face suddenly appeared from the darkness.

"Uncle Gong?"

"Shh. Keep your voice down."

---

[82] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses to address an older brother or an older man close to her.

Uncle Gong was a weary-looking middle-aged man. An old friend of Socheon's father, the Branch Leader of the Sakju Branch, he was now the young siblings' guide and protector.

"I was worried. You were gone for more than half a shichen.[83]"

"I should have been more careful. We have a tail."

"Already?"

"Yes. Every moment counts."

Socheon rose without hesitation. Uncle Gong hoisted the bewildered Soyul onto his back and led the way through the brush.

"Where are we going?"

"Honju. No matter how vicious those bastards are, they won't pursue us that far."

Is that really true?

Socheon had his doubts.

The Sakju Branch had already fallen. The building had burned, and everyone was dead. He did not know who the attackers were, but their purpose was clear.

Extermination.

He blew the word away with his breath and started walking again.

How long had they been walking?

The white snow that had fluttered down like sleet was already up to their calves when—

"Quiet."

Uncle Gong stopped. Socheon held his breath.

The howling wind. Bare branches clattering against one another…

Nothing else.

Yet Socheon knew instinctively.

"Is it them?"

Uncle Gong's face went rigid.

"At least ten of them. They'll catch up soon."

The situation was bleak. Yet strangely, Socheon's heart settled into a calm stillness.

"This is my fault. I should have hurried before the snow began… I curse the heavens."

"You did everything you could, Uncle."

Socheon drew the dagger from inside his clothes. It had been handed down to him by his father a year ago—the only trace his father had left behind.

"I've learned a little martial arts myself. I'll fight and die like a martial artist."

"…It's too soon to give up."

---

[83] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

That was all Uncle Gong could say. They drew on what little strength they had left and set off again.

But their stamina, pushed to its limit by days and nights of nonstop flight, dragged at their feet. Their steps grew slower, and their breathing became labored.

“There they are!”

“We’ve almost caught them!”

Now Socheon could hear them, too. The pursuers’ voices and the glow of their torches were drawing closer.

At that moment, Uncle Gong handed the soundly sleeping Soyul to Socheon.

“I’ll follow behind you.”

“Uncle!”

“Don’t worry. I, Gong Yacheong, am not so easily dealt with.”

“But how can you…”

“Go!”

Socheon left Gong Yacheong behind and started up the mountain again. His stamina was at its limit, but he did not stop.

When he reached a hill on the snow-covered mountain, the clash of weapons and someone’s scream rang out.

Uncle Gong.

Socheon gritted his teeth. He wanted to draw his dagger and throw himself down the slope that very instant.

But…

Hold on. I have to hold on.

He had repeated those words hundreds, thousands of times over the past five days. He had sworn to survive, protect the little sister in his arms, and take revenge on the murderers.

From the hilltop, Socheon stared at the flickering torches with fire blazing in his eyes.

I will survive.

Then he turned and climbed over the hill.

The next moment, his body shook as if struck by lightning.

“A-ah…”

Ten men in navy martial uniforms stood in the broad clearing atop the hill, staring at him.

A single character had been embroidered prominently across each man’s chest in silk thread.

□.

Jin.

I sensed something strange just as we were about to begin training.

A sound carried faintly through the howling wind. When I drew up my internal energy, it became clearer.

A human voice?

There had to be more than ten people. They were so close, I couldn't believe I had only just noticed them.

That many people in this weather…

All right. Decision made.

"Pack your things."

"Huh?"

The squad members had been standing ready with their weapons, but now they stared at me in confusion.

"Pack up, quickly. One of you, go inside and get Hyuk Mujin—"

"Captain. There's a kid over there."

Damn it. There really was one.

A little boy carrying an even smaller child on his back was staring blankly at us.

"Who's that?"

"No idea. Does he own this cabin?"

Please let that be it.

But why did I find it so hard to believe that the men following him were members of one big, happy family?

"He's crying."

As someone had pointed out, the boy was crying. Sobbing his heart out as he ran.

The problem was the direction he was running in.

"Uh, he's coming this way… Captain, where are you going?"

Suspicious gazes turned toward me. I had already backed well away from them.

"I'm going to ride a horse. We should be leaving soon."

"In this weather? The horses won't even be able to move."

"Really? Then we'll leave them behind."

"What?"

"That's how missions work. Snow or rain, we still have a job to do. Shut up and pack your things."

"But still…"

"Pack your things! Wake Hyuk Mujin!"

The admiring looks they had given me barely fifteen minutes ago had turned into the sort reserved for a lunatic.

“What’s gotten into you all of a sudden?”

What’s gotten into me?

I had a really bad feeling about this.

By now, I knew the signs. The closer the kid came, the stronger the stench of a giant fuck-you grew.

I could already see exactly how this would play out. There was only one way out.

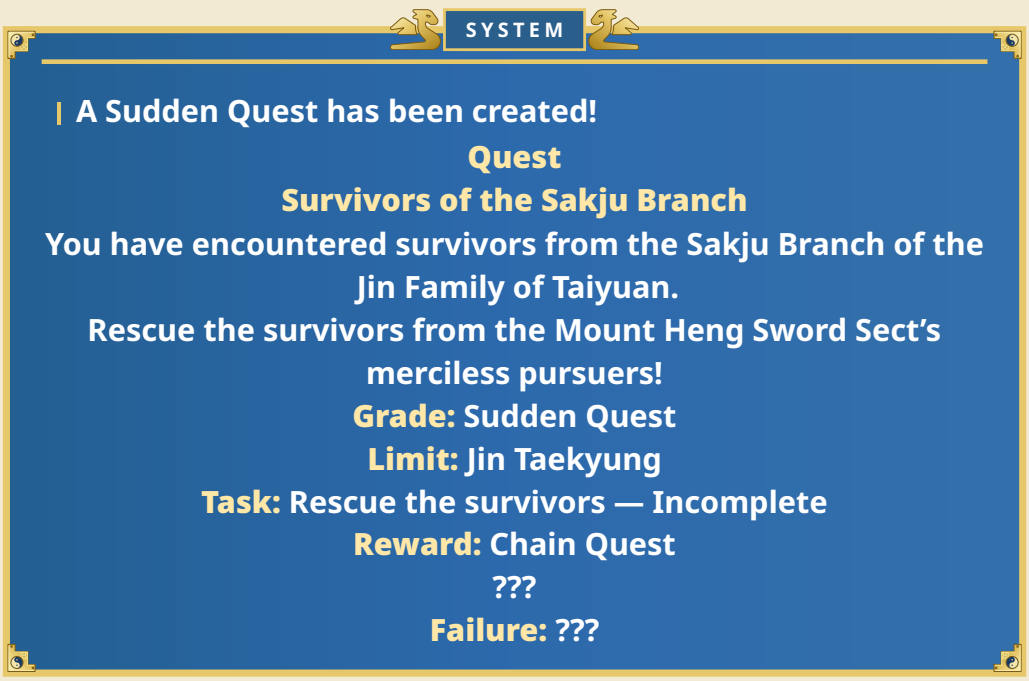
“Then I’ll head down first by my—”

At that moment, our uninvited guests appeared over the hill amid a chorus of shouts.

More than twenty men.

Oh, fuck.

Ding.



“…”

“…”

We stared at them. They stared at us.

A deathly silence settled over the frozen clearing.

I knew it. I knew this was going to happen.

But it was too late for regrets. What could I do about my shitty luck?

I heaved a deep sigh and shouted.

“Attack formation! Form up!”

Clack-clack-clack.

Caught off guard, the squad members nevertheless moved as they had been taught. By the time they had formed up, the enemy had realized who we were and started shouting.

“They’re brats from the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

“There aren’t many of them! Wipe them out!”

Brats. Outnumbered.

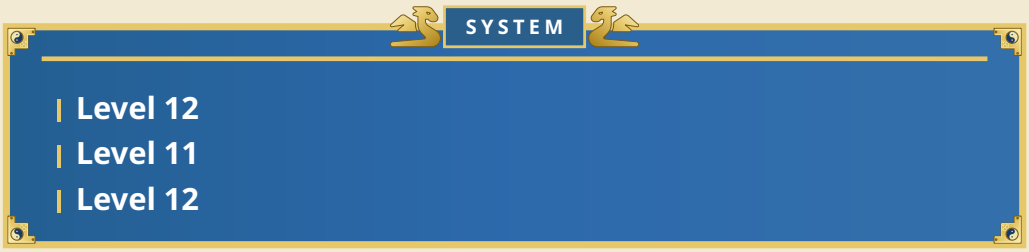
Those two facts hit me right in the chest.

I hadn’t even finished teaching these guys. Their martial arts were weak, they had no real combat experience, and they were complete rookies…

If this goes bad, should I run for it by myself?

With a growing sense of dread, I used Qi Sense. Blue waves of qi, visible only to me, swept over the enemies charging toward us with wild shrieks.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



“…Huh?”

The reconnaissance squad members shouted, their faces deathly pale.

“What do we do?”

“They’re coming! They’re coming!”

“Captaaaain!”

Thirty meters[84]. Twenty…[85]

I watched the enemy close in at terrifying speed and opened my mouth.

“Don’t worry. The enemy is nothing but EXP… I mean, a rabble. But!”

“But?”

“Stop them with everything you have. Just hold them back.”

“What? What do you mean?”

What do I mean?

Don’t take the last hit.

“Defensive formation! Form up!”

Yep. All the EXP was mine.

[84]Thirty meters is about 98 ft.

[85]Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

"Captain!"

"No! Captaaaain!"

"The Captain's trying to kill himself!"

That wasn't what I was doing, you lunatics.

Leaving the reconnaissance squad members' screams behind, I charged straight at the enemy.

Internal energy surged from my dantian and spread through my limbs and bones.

"You crazy bastard."

The man at the front grinned, baring yellow teeth.

I grinned back.

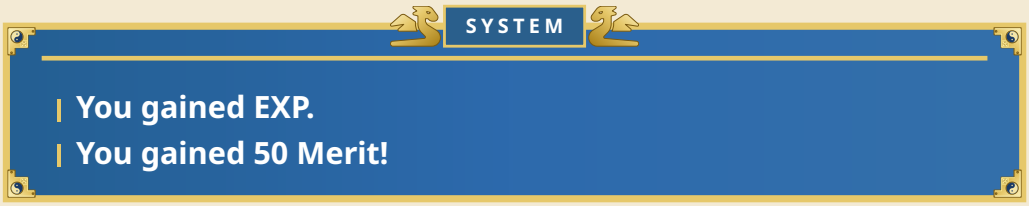
"Pretty boy."

"What?"

Slash.

He clutched his throat and collapsed. As I swept past him, the voice I had been waiting for rang out.

Ding.



"What the—!"

"How dare this fucking bastard…"

The enemy was a magnificent sight. Facial scars came standard, and their hygiene was so atrocious that the stench stabbed at my nose.

And yet…

"Ah, this is great."

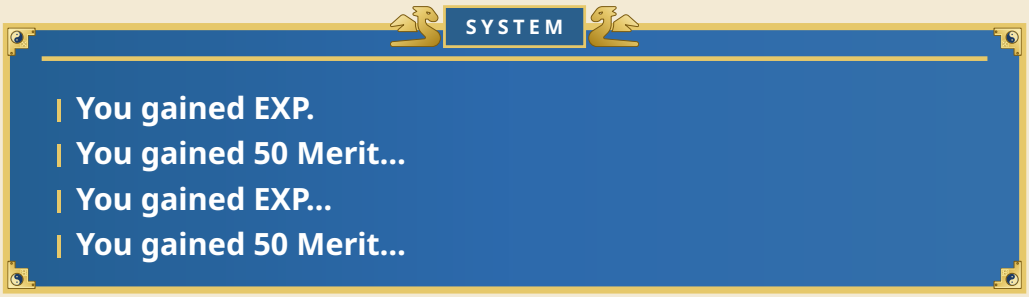
I felt like I was standing in a flower garden.

Twenty flowers, each brimming with the sweet honey of EXP.

I charged into them with a blissful expression and sucked out the honey.

Stab. Stab. Stab.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



I tore through their ranks without pause.

Their front line collapsed in the blink of an eye, and the others instinctively faltered.

That works for me.

The Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique and Spear Technique were martial arts built around advancing.

I stepped forward with the Manoeuvre Technique, drove into their center, and swung my spear.

"Gaaah!"

"Aaaargh!"

A razor-sharp spear with crushing weight behind it, wielded with an overwhelmingly aggressive technique. Better yet, the enemy was steadily retreating.

It was time for the Jin Family's Spear Technique to show its true worth.

First form.

I began swinging the spear in step with my footwork. Every swing and thrust brought forth someone's scream and a burst of blood.

"Ghk."

"Grrrgh."

Second form. Third form. Fourth form.

At some point, I surrendered myself to the flow.

The ripples became waves, and the enemies were swept away by them. Every nerve in my body stood on end.

More. More. More...

"You fucking bastard!"

Stab. Stab-stab.

Throat. Chest. Abdomen.

I stabbed and cut them down one after another. The System alerts confirmed the fatalities for me.

How much time had passed?

Only one man remained standing.

"O-our boss will find you no matter—"

I didn’t wait.

A wave was all about flow.

And the final wave erupted from the tip of my spear.

The last form of the Jin Family’s Spear Technique.

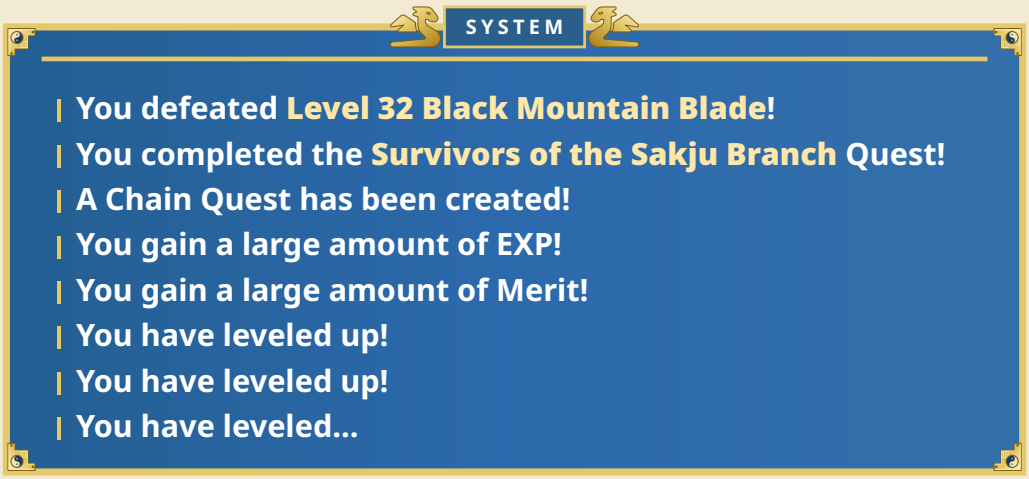
Sky-Piercing Strike.

Splurt!

The last man—the one with the narrow, birdlike eyes—stared at the shattered pieces of his sword before dropping to his knees.

The center of his chest had burst open as if struck by a cannonball.

Ding.



As the System alerts continued without pause, I rubbed my stomach.

“Buuurp.”

Ah, I’m stuffed.

Chapter 25

"Is this the afterlife?"

That was the first thing the middle-aged man said when he woke up.

Before I could answer, a small figure sprang forward and threw himself into the man's arms.

The boy cried out, his eyes brimming with tears.

"Uncle Gong!"

"Socheon! You're safe. But what in the world...?"

Socheon explained through his sobs that he had met us on the hill and that I had killed all their enemies. The middle-aged man's eyes widened.

"Are you from the main family?"

"Yes, I am."

"Ah, Heaven has helped us!"

"..."

I helped you, you old man.

"I was sure I'd fallen down the mountain... I thought that was the end of me."

"You nearly did. You were lucky."

I pointed below the ridge. Two corpses that appeared to belong to the enemy lay with their heads embedded in trees.

If the slope he had tumbled down hadn't been covered in thick undergrowth, he would have ended up just like them.

I didn't notice him at first, either.

I had only realized the middle-aged man was there because of the Quest Window.

Even after I defeated all the enemies, the **Survivors of the Sakju Branch** Quest had not been completed. That meant there were more survivors.

The question was whether there were any more besides him...

The last trace of unease vanished as soon as I helped the exhausted man to his feet.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You completed the Survivors of the Sakju Branch Quest!
A Chain Quest has been created!
You leveled up!
You leveled up!
Merit and Fame increase!

“Whew.”

The middle-aged man exhaled. Though he had only circulated his qi briefly, his complexion had improved noticeably.

He rose and respectfully clasped his hands in salute.

“Benefactor, you saved us all.”

“Not at all. I only did what anyone should have done.”

These days, lies came pouring out whenever I opened my mouth. Then again, it wasn’t entirely untrue. I had to clear the Quest somehow.

If anything, I should be the one bowing and thanking them.

Still, Santa Claus—or rather, the survivors—seemed deeply moved by my attitude.

“Such outstanding martial arts, and such chivalry as well. I, Gong Yacheong, sincerely admire you.”

“Socheon and Soyul owe you a tremendous debt, Great Hero.”

That was how I learned their names. The middle-aged man was Gong Yacheong, and the young siblings were Socheon and Soyul.

“If it isn’t too impertinent, may I ask your name, Benefactor?”

“My name is…”

Then a thought struck me.

Wait. If I tell them my name, won’t they come at me with swords?

Whatever conspiracy lay behind it, the person who had lit the fuse on this war was none other than me, Jin Taekyung. I doubted two people who had lost their home and family would feel kindly toward me.

Right. This calls for a well-intentioned lie.

“Hong Gil-dong. My name is Hong Gil-dong.”[86]

“Hong Gil-dong…[87] I’ve never heard the name before, but it has the air of a hero.”

Socheon chimed in from beside him.

“Here one moment, there the next. It sounds like the name of someone who could appear and disappear like a ghost.”

…How did that kid know?

Before he could bring up the part about calling one’s father Father and one’s elder brother Brother,[88] I hurriedly changed the subject.

“More importantly, what happened?”

Dark shadows fell across their faces.

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[86] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw and folk hero.

[87] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw and folk hero.

[88] In the Hong Gil-dong tale, he demands the right to address his father as “Father” and his elder brother as “Brother.”

Gong Yacheong spoke first.

“It happened only a few days ago.”

By the time the messenger pigeon arrived with news of the war, the Sakju Branch had already been surrounded so tightly that not even a drop of water could escape. The wandering martial artists hired by the Mount Heng Sword Sect slaughtered the people inside and set fire to the buildings.

“There were no fewer than a hundred of them. The Branch Leader and his martial artists bought us enough time to escape through a secret passage. Most of those who got out were women and children who knew no martial arts.”

I didn’t need to ask what had happened to the others.

The System was absolute and factual. According to the Quest Window, these three were the only survivors of the Sakju Branch.

“I want to know about the enemy.”

“They’re wandering martial artists.”

“Wandering martial artists?”

“As you know, they’re bastards who’ll do anything for money. The Mount Heng Sword Sect hired the worst of them to attack us.”

“They seemed pretty weak for such vile bastards.”

“What do good and evil have to do with strength? The ones they hired were ordinary wandering martial artists, common as dirt. Their leader was the problem.”

Gong Yacheong gritted his teeth.

“Jopil, One Question, One Kill. That was the man. The Branch Leader knew we were doomed the moment he saw him and entrusted his dependents to me.”

Socheon’s small fists trembled.

“I’ll tear him limb from limb and kill him with my own hands.”

That was an unusual choice of words for a child, but considering the grudge carved into his bones, it was understandable.

I patted Socheon on the head.

“And you will. I’ll help you.”

“Really?”

“A man’s word is worth a thousand pieces of gold. Do you think I’d say one thing and do another? I’ll definitely catch that bastard and level u—”

“Huh?”

“No, I mean I’ll kill him and avenge your grudge.”

“Ah… Thank you. Thank you so much, Great Hero Hong!”

“Thank you. Truly, thank you!”

The two of them repeatedly expressed their gratitude. I felt like a real scumbag, and a sharp stab tore through one corner of my chest.

No, this is fine. They'll be happy when their enemy dies, and I'll be happy when I level up. It's mutually beneficial. Mutually beneficial.

Having forced myself to accept that logic, I asked, "How many are there?"

"While scouting their position, I overheard them talking. They said there were about thirty, including Jopil."

"Thirty? Thirty men?"

"That's right. So we must flee at once…"

Gong Yacheong's voice faded into the distance. In its place, I heard a faint sound drawing closer.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

I could hear it—the sound of leveling up. The sound of logging out!

Struggling to keep the corners of my mouth from rising, I said, "Let's wait here for the rest of them."

"Wait? What do you mean?"

"We'll wipe them all out! We can't let such vile bastards live!"

"No, Great Hero Hong, listen to me…"

"A master like you can do it! Thank you, Benefactor!"

Socheon ran into my arms with tears in his eyes. I spread my arms and pulled him into a hug.

"That's right. Let's kill them all!"

"Let's kill them!"

"Jopil, you son of a bitch!"

"Son of a bitch!"

That was when Gong Yacheong spoke.

"Jopil is a Peak master."

"Jopil is a fucking bast—huh?"

"Jopil, One Question, One Kill. He's one of the few Peak masters in all of Shanxi. What do you think is the reason he has survived until now, despite being tangled up in all kinds of gratitude and grudges?"

"Don't tell me…"

"Everyone who challenged him died. That's the kind of man Jopil is. Cruel—and every bit as strong."

"Ah."

Sensing that something was wrong, Socheon looked up at me.

"Socheon."

"Yes, Great Hero."

"Now that I think about it, this probably isn't the right time."

"Huh?"

“I was being foolish. Our first priority should be getting you and your sister safely back to our family. Right?”

“…”

“I was injured during the fight, and my men are exhausted. It would probably be a difficult battle.”

Socheon looked me up and down. My clothes were soaked in the enemies’ blood, but they were perfectly intact, without a single tear. There was no way I could have been injured.

“I suffered an internal injury.”

“…”

This time, he turned to the reconnaissance squad. They hadn’t even swung their swords during the fight and were practically overflowing with energy.

“Things aren’t always what they seem.”

“…Great Hero.”

I gently pulled Socheon away and shouted, “We’re returning to the main family. Everyone, prepare to leave!”

I hurried back toward the squad, but Socheon’s hand clutched my collar tightly and refused to let go. Tears glimmered in his round eyes.

“Great Hero.”

“Hey, why aren’t you moving? Move, move! Socheon, I’m a little busy right now, so let’s talk later. Okay?”

“Great Heeero.”

“Mister Gong Yacheong. No, Great Hero Gong, what are you doing? Every second counts.”

“…Socheon, come here.”

Gong Yacheong looked at me as if I were a complete idiot and pulled Socheon away. It was the protective gesture of a guardian keeping a criminal away from his child.

Socheon practically wailed.

“Great Hero Hong Gil-dooong!”

That was the signal.

Boom!

The cabin door shattered, and someone burst through it.

SYSTEM

Level 22 Hyuk Mujin

“Jin Taekyung, you fucking bastard!”

Hyuk Mujin stood there panting, his furious eyes fixed squarely on me. Gong Yacheong and Socheon stared at me blankly.

“Great Hero Hong?”

“Great Hero Hong Gil-dong?”[89]

“Ah. Well, you see…”

…*Fuck.*

“Hmm.”

Jopil stared silently down at the corpse. Its face was twisted, its eyes bulging. Frozen beneath blood and snow, the man had once been known as Black Mountain Blade.

“Tsk, tsk. How did you end up like this, my friend?”

He had been fairly loyal and sharp. Jopil had never imagined he would meet such a pointless end.

“See? Haven’t I told you time and again to keep your eyes wide open?”

Jopil grabbed Black Mountain Blade’s bulging eyelids and pried them farther apart.

The frozen flesh tore with a hideous sound.

Rip. Riiip.

The others watched without daring to breathe.

His expression and tone were no different from usual, but they could feel in their bones that Jopil was furious.

The killing intent radiating from the Peak master left them struggling for breath, cold sweat trickling down their backs.

And no wonder.

More than twenty men had been wiped out while carrying out a simple mission to dispose of the remnants of the Sakju Branch.

Jopil was called One Question, One Kill because of his bizarre habit of asking any enemy who caught his interest exactly one question before killing them.

The wandering martial artists were relieved that Black Mountain Blade was dead. If he had survived, he would have suffered an even more horrifying fate.

“That’s better.”

Jopil wiped the blood on the front of his trousers and rose.

“So, what does everyone think? Speak freely.”

“We should follow our orders, of course.”

[89] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw and folk hero.

One man stepped forward. The neatly dressed, dignified middle-aged man and the dozen or so martial artists standing at attention behind him were the overseers and guides the Mount Heng Sword Sect had sent to keep the wandering martial artists under control.

Jopil smiled faintly.

“Ah, yes. I’d forgotten the Hall Master of the great Mount Heng Sword Sect was here. But what’s this about an order?”

“Erase the Sakju Branch and rejoin the main force. Have you already forgotten the Young Sect Leader’s order?”

“An order? I remember accepting a commission.”

“Isn’t that the same thing?”

The middle-aged man glared at Jopil, displeased.

“Coming this far was your own unilateral decision. And what came of it? You lost more than twenty subordinates to the remnants of a single branch!”

“Which is why we should pursue them. We can finish them off in half a day.”

“Jeongyang might be one thing, but if we pursue them as far as Honju, we risk a counterattack. I won’t permit any more unilateral decisions.”

“Permission. Permission…”

After mulling it over, Jopil spoke.

“No. That won’t do. I don’t like it.”

“What do you mea—”

Crunch.

The middle-aged man’s neck shattered, killing him before he could finish. Jopil had snapped it with blinding speed. He licked his lips.

“I like war. No matter who dies, they’re forgotten.”

“You bastard!”

The Mount Heng Sword Sect’s martial artists realized what had happened and drew their weapons, but Jopil had already plunged into their midst.

Crunch! Slash!

Warm blood poured across the snow. Every time Jopil rampaged like a wild beast, someone’s neck, arm, or leg was torn free and sent flying.

“Gaaah…”

The groan of an unnamed martial artist was the last sound.

Standing atop the heap of corpses, Jopil spoke into the crushing silence.

“We’re pursuing them.”

This time, no one said a word. As his subordinates hurried to prepare as though fleeing for their lives, Jopil continued to stare at the bodies.

What kind of man was it?

He was a Peak master. From the wounds on the corpses and the footprints left behind, he could reconstruct his opponent.

Only one man. A highly skilled spearman had been here. He was the one who had slaughtered the other twenty-odd men.

If he killed Black Mountain Blade in one strike, he must be something else.

The final strike that pierced through Black Mountain Blade's chest had been particularly interesting.

This should be a fun fight.

Who was he? A master from the Jin Family of Taiyuan? Or someone unknown?

It didn't matter. Jopil let out a pleased laugh.

"Let's meet soon, friend."

"What news has come in?"

"None. All we can do is move as quickly as possible…"

"Damn it! Damn it!"

Wipeng vented his frustration, but there was nothing he could do. As his subordinate had said, their only option was to find the Third Young Master as quickly as possible and protect him.

Jopil, One Question, One Kill…

Wipeng knew the man's reputation well. If the Third Young Master fell into his hands, death would be the only possible outcome.

If that happens, I won't be able to face my lord.

Jin Wikyung had endured with superhuman patience.

He currently stood at the head and center of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. He had weighed his beloved younger brother against the lives of hundreds of family members and, after long deliberation, sent his most trusted subordinate, Wipeng, to protect him.

But if I fail…

I won't be able to face my lord.

His grip tightened around the reins. Wipeng spurred his horse onward, with more than twenty mounted riders racing in a long line behind him.

Chapter 26

"So…"

Gong Yacheong gave me a strange look.

"So you're that Young Master Jin Taekyung."

The moment had finally come. I let go of Hyuk Mujin's collar—he'd passed out for the third time—and smiled awkwardly.

"Yes. I'm Jin Taekyung."

The reconnaissance squad members preparing camp pricked up their ears. We were on our way back to the family estate.

We had ridden for more than five hours without a break since leaving the cabin where the fight had taken place. Gong Yacheong had remained silent the entire way. Only now did he finally speak.

If it weren't for that bastard.

I glared at Hyuk Mujin as one of the quicker-witted squad members dragged him away. I should've hit him one more time before letting go.

While I was regretting that missed opportunity, Gong Yacheong continued.

"I've heard plenty about you, Young Master."

"…I see."

"Even a three-year-old knows who you are. You must be the main family's biggest celebrity."

At this point, it would probably be faster to find someone who hadn't heard of me.

"Lazy by nature and arrogant beyond belief. Addicted to wine and women, without even bothering to learn martial arts… But it seems the rumors of the martial world truly can't be trusted. The prowess you displayed today was remarkable."

"…"

If there were such a thing as the Martial World Daily, collecting all the latest rumors from across Murim, I'd subscribe immediately. It seemed surprisingly reliable.

More importantly…

Did Gong Yacheong really not know?

Whatever bullshit the Mount Heng Sword Sect had pulled, I was at the center of this entire mess.

It was an undeniable fact that countless people had died along the way.

It wouldn't have been strange for Gong Yacheong and Socheon to hold a grudge against me. That was why I had hidden my name.

If he really doesn't know, that's a relief.

We were being chased by a ruthless Peak master. I had no interest in stirring up extra trouble.

“How long until we reach the main family?”

Gong Yacheong’s question snapped me back to reality.

“We should arrive in two or three days.”

“Of all times, it had to snow now…”

Gong Yacheong sighed and glared resentfully at the sky, which was still dumping snow on us.

“Young Master, we should prepare for the worst.”

“The worst?”

The blizzard had us stuck, but it had our enemies stuck too. There was even a chance they had given up the chase.

But Gong Yacheong shook his head.

“Don’t underestimate wandering martial artists. Their internal energy may be less refined, and the martial arts they’ve learned may be inferior, but their greatest weapon lies elsewhere.”

I gave him the answer.

“Experience.”

“Exactly. Experience gained through a hundred battles. The ones chasing us aren’t merely martial artists. They’re wandering martial artists. The two may seem alike, but they’re entirely different creatures.”

Alike, yet different. I thought I understood what he meant.

In short, they were well-trained hunting dogs. And the man holding their leash was Jopil, One Question, One Kill.

“What makes Jopil truly frightening isn’t simply that he’s a Peak master. It’s his persistence. His viciousness. He has never once failed a commission or allowed a target to escape.”

I answered with a sigh.

“This time won’t be any different, then.”

“Probably.”

Gong Yacheong stared into the darkness ahead as though something might leap out and swallow us whole.

“That is the sort of man pursuing us.”

Whoosh.

The snow-laden wind vanished into the darkness.

We finished making camp. We had dug several small hollows and covered their entrances with branches, fallen leaves, and whatever else we could find. The shelters were crude, but this was no time to be choosy.

“Have a restful night.”

Gong Yacheong disappeared into one of them, carrying the siblings, who had already fallen fast asleep. I couldn’t stop thinking about the weary smile hanging from the corner of his mouth.

He really is an adult.

If he had wanted to live, he could have run away long ago. Gong Yacheong was a trained master, a seasoned man of the martial world.

But he hadn’t.

He had risked his life fighting for two children who didn’t share a drop of his blood.

That was why Gong Yacheong was a good adult.

Could I do the same?

I shook off the question as soon as it arose. This was a game. It wasn’t wise to think too deeply about an illusion that would soon disappear.

That was right. An illusion that would soon disappear.

Open Quest Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Logout
You must now make your way through this harsh Murim.
Become stronger. Become famous.
For the day that will come someday…
Grade: Main Quest
Limit: Jin Taekyung
Task: Reach the First Rate realm — Incomplete
Reach Lv. 30 — 24/30
Reach Fame 500 — 250/500
Reward: Logout

The EXP and Fame I had gained from dealing with the enemies, plus the Quest reward.

I could finally see the summit of this treacherous mountain.

I opened my Status Window and distributed all my remaining points. Vitality flowed back into my exhausted body.

I’m almost there.

I just had to get past this final hurdle. If I could avoid Jopil, One Question, One Kill—the bastard whose face I didn't even know—I could finally bring this miserable journey to an end.

But there was another problem.

Let's say I somehow fill up my Level and Fame. How the hell am I supposed to raise my realm?

Back when I first started clearing the tutorial Quests, distributing my stats had raised my realm from Third Rate to Second Rate. Since then, nothing.

What the hell am I missing?

I was an absurd existence in Murim. I could learn martial arts and raise my stats faster than anyone else. The System had helped me grow stronger in all kinds of ways.

That was why I could literally wipe the floor with ordinary First Rate martial artists despite being a dime-a-dozen Second Rate.

And yet I wasn't First Rate!

I should've asked Jin Wikyung.

At first, I had assumed I just needed to keep raising my stats or internal energy. Lately, though, I had begun to suspect I was barking up the wrong tree.

Level? Stats? Internal energy?

What was it? What final piece did I need to complete the puzzle?

The answer came quickly.

If I don't know, I have to find out.

Just as I always had. If I kept walking, I would eventually find the exit.

I sat cross-legged and steadied my breathing. The internal energy coiled within my dantian answered my call.

"We lost them."

Jopil muttered as his black, viper-like eyes swept across the surroundings.

They had lost the fugitives. But traces remained, faint signs that would serve as new guideposts.

"About twenty people. They left this place roughly two shichen ago."[90]

Jopil nodded at his subordinate's report. The man's martial arts were only Third Rate, but his tracking skills had reached the Peak. Jopil had countless hunting dogs like him under his command.

Two shichen.[91]

[90] A shichen is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours.
[91] A shichen is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours.

The gap had already narrowed to two shichen.[92] How much longer would it take them to catch the fugitives?

Half a day at most.

They should have run with everything they had. Without looking back. They should have cast off every burden, abandoned anyone who fell behind, and run for their lives.

If they had done that, the distance would not have narrowed. But they had let their guard down. They must have thought the blizzard had them trapped.

That misjudgment had brought them to this point.

But I'm a little different.

The previous night had been long. Even among his subordinates, men well accustomed to pursuit, some had fallen behind.

In the mountains during a blizzard, falling behind was no different from death.

The only difference from dying on a battlefield was that it took a little longer.

That was why Jopil had given the order.

Kill them.

They said a tiger left its hide when it died, while a person left their name.

But Jopil thought differently. What kind of name could a Third Rate nobody who'd spent his whole life drifting through back alleys leave behind?

They should at least leave a hide.

Leaving twenty stripped corpses behind, the group had pressed onward. When the long night finally ended, they discovered the fugitives' trail shortly before dawn.

We'll meet soon, friend.

The corners of Jopil's mouth curled upward. This mysterious master was the first person in a long time to pique his interest.

His heart, stiff for so long, began to pound.

I shuddered.

"Ugh. What the hell?"

A sudden chill ran through me. I raised my arm and found it covered in goose bumps.

If this had been a scene in a novel, the protagonist would have muttered that something felt wrong, then continued on his way.

But I was different. I had a solid hunch, and I acted on it.

"Hey. Get over here, quick."

[92] A shichen is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours.

I couldn’t see him, but I could sense him. The footsteps of someone trudging along behind me faltered.

“W-why?”

“I’m counting to three. One, two… three.”

The moment I reached three, Hyuk Mujin hurried over and stuck to my side.

“It was you, wasn’t it?”

“What?”

“You were the one. Tell me the truth and I’ll let it slide.”

“What are you talking about? It wasn’t me!”

I silently stared at his face, swollen like a steamed bun.

“You were cursing me behind my back just now, weren’t you?”

“Gasp.”

“You were, weren’t you?”

“I-I was…”

So it really had been this bastard. When I raised my hand, Hyuk Mujin squeezed his eyes shut.

After getting beaten about three times, he had lost all his fighting spirit. On top of that, he had learned a valuable life lesson:

Dodging only meant getting hit more.

“Fine. Since you told the truth, I’ll let it slide this once.”

Hyuk Mujin’s head shot up.

“Really?”

I gave him a warm smile.

“Of course. But don’t even think about deceiving me from now on. I’ll be watching you with mind-reading.”[93]

Hyuk Mujin stared at me with eyes full of demonic rage, then darted back to his place. If only we’d had more time, I could have smashed his head in with a mace.

Swallowing my regret, I kept walking.

“What’s mind-reading?”[94]

The chirping voice tickled my ear. It belonged to Soyul, Socheon’s little sister. Had they said she was five?

She was small enough to fit right inside my backpack.

“Is it martial arts?”

“Something like that.”

[93] Gwansimbeop, rendered here as “mind-reading,” evokes a supposed ability associated with the one-eyed Gung Ye in a Korean historical television drama.

[94] Gwansimbeop, rendered here as “mind-reading,” evokes a supposed ability associated with the one-eyed Gung Ye in a Korean historical television drama.

"Is mind-reading strong?"[95]

"Very strong."

"Wow! Soyul wants to learn mind-reading too!"[96]

"But you have to be one-eyed."

"Gasp!"

I glanced back and saw Soyul staring at me in shock, her eyes enormous. She was ridiculously cute.

Hayeon used to be like that too.

These days she was a creepy little sister, but when she was little she had been a baby angel. She had even gotten offers to be a child model…

Having her around felt exactly like piggybacking Hayeon at that age.

"Want me to teach you?"

"…Soyul doesn't like martial arts. I want to become a proper young lady."

"That's good too."

"Mm. Mister, do you like martial arts?"

"Me?"

"My brother says you're really strong. Dad said only people who work hard can become strong."

"Your dad said that?"

"Yes. My dad is really strong too. That's because…"

Soyul chattered excitedly for a long while before sticking out her lower lip.

"Soyul wants to see Dad. But I guess Dad doesn't want to see us. Oppa[97] says he went out to play with Mom, leaving me and Oppa[98] behind."

My heart dropped with a thud.

An old memory filled my vision. In a funeral hall draped in black and white, little Hayeon had searched for our father, and I had been forced to tell her an obvious lie.

Just as Socheon had done for Soyul.

It was the only thing I could say.

"…I see."

What else could I say?

I looked at Socheon, who was following in the middle of the formation. He was breathing hard, drenched in sweat.

He must be exhausted.

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[95] Gwansimbeop, rendered here as "mind-reading," evokes a supposed ability associated with the one-eyed Gung Ye in a Korean historical television drama.

[96] Gwansimbeop, rendered here as "mind-reading," evokes a supposed ability associated with the one-eyed Gung Ye in a Korean historical television drama.

[97] Oppa is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or an older man close to her.

[98] Oppa is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or an older man close to her.

His willpower was far beyond his years. The saying that pain made people mature was fucking bullshit, but it was true.

Socheon had never fallen behind even once, and the other reconnaissance squad members marveled at him for it.

But the real problem is somewhere else.

Gong Yacheong.

His face was deathly pale; he still hadn't shaken off his injuries. If not for the remarkable effects of the fasting pills I had given him, and the qi he had circulated last night, he might have collapsed long ago.

At this rate, they'll catch us.

Even after sunrise, the deep snow showed no sign of melting. I was leading the way and breaking a path through it, but everyone was exhausted, and our pace kept slowing.

Worse, we had an injured man and two children with us.

Should I run away on my own?

The thought came to me in an instant.

It was a game. So what?

Gong Yacheong, the young siblings, every member of the reconnaissance squad—they were all artificially created intelligences. Nothing more than NPCs.

But me?

I was alive. I was the only real person among them. The only one who truly existed.

But…

Fuck. It's such a simple problem… So why am I like this?

An inexplicable aversion surged up. It was strong enough to startle me—strong enough to throw me off.

Why?

I didn't know.

For hours afterward, I failed to find the answer.

And then night fell.

Chapter 27

"Fifteen-minute break."

The reconnaissance squad collapsed with a collective hiss, like the air going out of them.

They looked exhausted, but I wasn't particularly worried about those guys. As I'd observed, they had solid basic stamina, and during the battle they had done nothing but stand around and watch.

The other two were the problem…

"Are you all right?"

"Huff. I'm fine. I'm fine."

Socheon answered between ragged breaths. He didn't look ready to collapse just yet, but if he kept going like this, he would reach his limit before long.

Stubborn little brat.

Earlier, I had offered to carry both him and his sister. He had flatly refused.

"If it gets too hard, tell me. I can handle the two of you."

"Huff. I'm fine as I am. This is enough."

Doesn't look like it.

"I'm saying this for everyone's sake. Don't answer so quickly."

"Understood."

His eyes hardened with resolve. I handed the sleeping Soyul to him and turned away.

"Great Hero Gong."

The pale-faced man raised his head.

"…Young Master Jin."

His voice sounded ready to give out at any moment. His condition was worse than I'd thought. *Are you all right?* rose to the tip of my tongue, then faded away.

"How much longer can you hold out?"

"I don't know."

His answer was honest—and serious.

"What about the fasting pills?"

I had given him several of the fasting pills I had left. But Gong Yacheong shook his head.

"They weren't much help. Some quack must have made them. All they did was ruin my appetite. Hahaha."

"…Was that supposed to make me laugh?"

"It wasn't funny?"

"No. Not at all."

“What a shame… Cough!”

A sudden cough.

Drops of blood fell onto the white snow.

Damn it.

Worried that someone might see, I hurriedly stepped in front of Gong Yacheong.

“What’s going on? You weren’t this bad before.”

His condition had deteriorated rapidly in half a day. Gong Yacheong no longer looked merely exhausted. He looked unmistakably ill.

“It was inevitable.”

The calm look in his eyes made it even more ominous. I brushed aside the hand trying to stop me and pulled up the front of his robe.

“Ah.”

His body was covered in all kinds of wounds. But what shocked me were the blue veins spreading outward from his lower abdomen.

“What is this…? Don’t tell me…”

Gong Yacheong weakly fastened his robe again. He seemed worried that someone else—especially Socheon and Soyul—might see.

“Those wolf-like bastards coated their weapons with poison.”

Now I understood why Gong Yacheong hadn’t recovered even after taking the fasting pills. They could only stave off hunger and restore stamina. They had no detoxifying effect whatsoever.

“You should’ve told me sooner!”

“Those bastards must have been short on money. They used cheap poison. It was so weak that I didn’t notice until last night. By then, it was too late.”

Gong Yacheong’s stamina had already been at rock bottom when he was poisoned. Then he had continued forcing himself through this weather…

“Is there anything we can do?”

“There is.”

“Tell me.”

“But time won’t allow it. I can’t waste such precious time on one person.”

He was right.

But still…

“We have to try.”

“Young Master.”

“Everyone’s exhausted. If we rest for one shichen[99]—no, just half a shichen[100]—and try the method, that should be enough.”

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[99] A shichen is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours.

[100] A shichen is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours.

“Hahaha.”

“Please don’t laugh. I was planning to stop and rest around here anyway…”

I didn’t even know what I was saying anymore. As Gong Yacheong watched me ramble, a faint smile touched his lips.

“Go.”

“…”

“You know it too, don’t you? If we waste time here, we’ll be held back.”

I fell silent.

He was right. I had been considering this possibility since I saw his precarious complexion and the blood he coughed up. Perhaps I had been thinking about it since last night.

So this is how it ends?

I had to leave Gong Yacheong behind. If we took him with us, he might survive for now, but everyone’s pace would slow.

What if I carried him myself?

Even with the System’s help, I was still human. I had spent two days at the head of the group, breaking a path through the snow, and the fatigue had built up.

Two fasting pills left.

The thirty or so fasting pills I’d started with were almost gone. Could I escape their clutches while carrying Gong Yacheong with only two pills left?

And if we still ended up running into them, would I be able to fight them while exhausted? Would I be able to face Jopil, One Question, One Kill, a Peak master?

The answer had been clear for a long time.

We both knew it.

“Please take care of the children.”

The moment Gong Yacheong spoke, a System notification chimed.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Gong Yacheong’s Last Request
He wants only one thing now. See that the surviving children make it back safely.
Grade: None
Limit: Jin Taekyung
Task: Socheon and Soyul’s safe return (Incomplete)
Reward: None
Would you like to accept the Quest?

No reward.

It was the most shameless Quest I had ever received.

I'm busy trying to stay alive myself, old man.

But I nodded. If accepting it could ease the nagging discomfort in the corner of my heart, I would gladly do it.

"Let's do that."

Gong Yacheong smiled in satisfaction.

"You're saying we're leaving Great Hero Gong behind?"

Han Yeop muttered with a shocked expression. Hyuk Mujin said nothing, as though he was lost in thought, while the other reconnaissance squad members were busy watching one another's faces.

"Yes."

"That makes no sense!"

"Keep your voice down."

Nothing good would come of Socheon finding out. He was exactly the sort of kid who would insist on staying behind with Gong Yacheong.

"B-but this…"

"It was Great Hero Gong's decision. I agree with him."

That was when Hyuk Mujin abruptly spoke up.

"Why?"

Has this bastard not been beaten enough?

I glared at him, but Hyuk Mujin neither flinched nor backed down. My clenched fist slowly relaxed.

"His condition is serious. If we keep taking him with us, the rest of us will be in danger too."

"Is that all?"

"Yes."

Han Yeop cut in, his face flushed.

"No."

"It's an order."

"Then I'll disobey."

Everyone stared at Han Yeop in surprise.

I hadn't expected the boy who had declared himself my ardent follower from the very first time we met to use the word *disobey*, either.

"That won't change anything."

"We can't leave him behind like this."

“And if we can’t leave him behind?”

A wave of exhaustion suddenly washed over me. I rubbed my gritty eyes.

“If we can’t leave him behind, will you carry him?”

“Yes. I’ll carry him.”

“And you’ll get tired soon.”

If Han Yeop got tired, someone else would step forward to help him. Then they would grow tired one by one, our pace would slow, and the enemy would catch up.

“We’re up against battle-hardened wandering martial artists led by a Peak master. Do you think we’ll survive?”

Han Yeop lowered his head without answering. The other reconnaissance squad members avoided my gaze as well.

Only one person kept looking me in the eye.

“Number One. Do you still have something to say?”

After a long silence, Hyuk Mujin bowed his head.

“I’ll follow your orders, Captain.”

We began moving again.

Just before we left, Gong Yacheong gently stroked Socheon and Soyul’s heads with a peaceful expression.

“I’ll see you soon.”

Socheon nodded bravely. Still half-asleep, Soyul whimpered and nestled into my arms.

Every time I heard her soft breathing, something twisted uncomfortably in my chest.

Has he left by now?

Gong Yacheong hadn’t wanted the children to know he was gone. He had told me he would quietly slip away while we were moving.

Socheon was in the middle of the formation, so the reconnaissance squad members would block his view. He wouldn’t see Gong Yacheong leave.

How long has it been since we set out?

A sikyeong[101]? Half a shichen[102]?

I didn’t know. In the dead of night, with darkness swallowing everything around us, I couldn’t even feel the passage of time.

With every step I took, one thought refused to leave my mind.

He must have left by now.

[101] A sikyeong is the time it takes to eat a meal, roughly thirty minutes.

[102] A shichen is a traditional Chinese unit of time equal to roughly two hours.

It was only natural. Gong Yacheong and I both knew it, and everyone in the reconnaissance squad except Han Yeop had accepted it.

Most importantly…

I had a family waiting for me. I had a real world out there that I still had to face.

Then why does this feel so damn awful?

My feet felt heavy.

It wasn't just the snow piled up to my calves. It wasn't the grass and branches blocking the path ahead.

A mere NPC named Gong Yacheong kept weighing on my mind.

I remembered his final smile. The cheap Quest with no reward.

I remembered Han Yeop's defiance, and Hyuk Mujin's calm gaze pricked the corner of my heart like a thorn.

It's only natural. So why?

Because it was a game.

Because it was only a game.

If I didn't leave him behind, everyone would die. I'd die too! You fucking bastards!

"Fuuuck…"

The curse lodged in my throat finally spilled out.

Soyul stirred from her light sleep, mumbled something, and wrapped her arms around my neck.

Her tiny hands were cold. So real that goose bumps rose across my skin. Too real for me to believe this was only a game.

Real enough to make me feel guilty for abandoning a single NPC.

"…What a fucked-up game."

I turned around.

"Where are you going?"

I strode back the way we had come. I couldn't see Socheon's face or the faces of the reconnaissance squad members.

That was why I didn't notice the fleeting smile on Hyuk Mujin's face as he asked where I was going.

Or that Han Yeop, who should have been at the very rear, was nowhere to be seen.

"Huff. Huuuff."

I raced across the snow like the wind.

And then I found him.

Below the hill, Han Yeop was gritting his teeth and forcing one foot in front of the other, even as he gasped for breath.

The unconscious Gong Yacheong was on his back.

"You…"

I didn't know what to say. With a sigh, I grabbed Han Yeop's hand and pulled him up.

"Th-thank you."

Shit…

I don't know anymore, either.

This was a hidden retreat meant for one person alone.

Since becoming its owner thirty years ago, he had forbidden anyone else from entering. As the years passed, that prohibition had hardened into an unbreakable rule, and everyone else regarded it as such.

"How are things going?"

The air trembled faintly as the two shadows conversed through Sound Transmission.

"Smoothly. And on your end?"

"Do you even need to ask?"

"I wouldn't expect otherwise."

"The Blood Wolf Sword. For someone with that epithet, he's surprisingly fond of his family."

"Even a wolf cares for its own flesh and blood. So?"

"The vanguard alone numbers two hundred. A madman named Jopil is running wild as he pleases, but… it should be fine."

"Jopil, One Question, One Kill? The Blood Wolf Sword chose well."

"The wastrel young master is being chased for his life. It wasn't part of the plan, but it isn't a bad development."

"Hahahaha."

"Could it be…?"

"That's right. I sent him. Once the Lesser Family Head sees the head of his beloved youngest brother, he'll change his mind."

"Whew. A heart as cold as poison, without blood or tears. Impressive."

"Is that something you should be saying?"

"I only took one hopeless life."

"And thanks to that, a bloody storm will sweep through Shanxi Province?"

"Isn't that what you wanted?"

"I can't deny it. Yes. I've waited far too long."

"The fruit will taste all the sweeter."

"I hope so."

"Ah, right. The Lower District Sect has gotten involved."

“The Lower District Sect? How?”

“The new Branch Leader has a keen nose. Once this matter is settled, I intend to drive them out.”

“Be careful. No matter how formidable Heaven may be, you must never let your guard down…”

At that moment, the wind stopped.

The air quivered.

“…I misspoke.”

A long silence passed before another Sound Transmission came.

“You would do well to mind your words and actions.”

The voice was as soft as a cat’s paw.

But the listener could feel the cold, razor-sharp blade beneath it.

“Let me apologize once more.”

“Let’s end things here for today. If a problem arises, I’ll come see you again soon.”

The conversation ended there.

The other person vanished without a sound or trace.

They’re like ghosts.

Sometimes, he wondered what their true identities were. How strong were they? Who were their members?

But he soon shook his head.

Such curiosity would only shorten my life.

He had endured years of hardship to reap the fruit. He couldn’t let mere curiosity ruin his plans.

It truly has been a long time.

The shadow reached toward the moon. Faint moonlight slipped between his fingers, illuminating his silver beard.

Soon… everything will return to its rightful place.

The Head Elder smiled with delight.

Chapter 28

Hoo.

I sat cross-legged and evened out my breathing. The breath I exhaled still carried qi I hadn't managed to gather.

What a waste.

Circulating qi meant drawing in energy from outside, cycling it together with my internal energy, and accumulating it. But only a small amount remained in my body.

Most of it returned to nature.

In novels, you could shoot up just by doing a little of this.

The greatest martial arts under heaven? An elixir of the ages?

Not here. The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was Peak-grade, but it was hopeless at accumulating internal energy. And elixirs? Bullshit. I hadn't even gotten a look at one. All I'd done was suffer like hell.

Is that my only hope?

Another mass of internal energy crouched in a corner of my dantian. If I could make all of it mine, it would be a huge help in the fights ahead.

The problem was that no matter how many times I tried, it wouldn't budge.

Move. Move!

As if the thing that had sat there like a boulder this whole time was going to start moving. I tried drawing up my internal energy, but it gave me nothing. I sighed and got to my feet.

"Are we leaving?"

Hyuk Mujin had been watching our surroundings.

"Yeah."

"Understood."

Then he briskly got the reconnaissance squad ready and scooped Soyul into his arms. I stared at him in disbelief.

What the hell did this bastard eat?

Why had he suddenly gotten so efficient?

This was the guy who used to move only when I shoved a fist in his face. Somehow, he seemed like a different person.

Not that I'm complaining.

I shoved the stray thoughts aside and slung Gong Yacheong onto my back. As the poisoning worsened, his face had turned a dark blue.

Hyuk Mujin asked worriedly, "Will he be all right?"

"He has to be."

I'd already done everything I could. All that remained was to hope Gong Yacheong held on. I muttered to the unconscious man.

"Not much farther. Just hold on a little longer."

Sunlight squeezed through the dim dawn. I took a long stride toward it.

No—I started to.

• Awoooooo!

At first, I thought it was the wind. But those were the cries of living beasts. Hyuk Mujin muttered,

"The wolves must be hungry."

"Wolves?"

"Of course. It's hardly strange for there to be wild animals in the mountains."

This was a game set in ancient China. It wouldn't be strange for wolves or tigers to leap out from anywhere. I'd heard wild animals crying more than once over the past few days.

But…

Something feels off.

This wasn't like the others. Just hearing those howls made my chest tighten and my fingertips tingle.

The gut I'd honed over seven years seemed to whisper. Something was beyond that forest, where the sunlight hadn't reached yet.

"Prepare for battle."

"Then we're leaving now… Huh?"

"Form a defensive formation."

Hyuk Mujin quickly recovered and relayed my order. Three reconnaissance squad members carrying shields clad in thin iron blocked the snow-covered path.

A narrow trail and the high ground atop a hill. We had the advantage.

• Awoooooo!

A second howl rang out. Closer—and all the more ominous for it. Hyuk Mujin spoke carefully.

"It sounds like nothing more than a pack of wolves…"

"Then that's even better."

"Won't this delay us too long?"

I shook my head. We'd been fleeing for two full days. If this brief pause was what got us caught, then it was fate.

"Hold. We'll wait a little longer."

The beasts seemed to understand me. For the next fifteen minutes, the howls continued without pause, drawing ever closer. Snapping branches and paws racing over the snow shattered the stillness of the mountain at dawn.

"Doesn't sound like one or two."

Hyuk Mujin glanced at my face.

“From the sound, there must be dozens… Wolves are pack animals, but this is strange.”

No sooner had he finished than the pack emerged. Maybe they hadn’t been able to find prey in winter; most of them were so gaunt that their ribs showed. But they were still predators. We couldn’t let our guard down.

Hungry predators, at that. The kids could get hurt.

And yet, contrary to my thoughts, I felt oddly relieved. The place might be crawling with martial artists, but surely even the beasts hadn’t learned martial arts.

Forget gut feelings—these were easy opponents.

I skip a few raids and my touch is completely gone.

I clicked my tongue and stepped forward. The dozens of wolves charging toward us already looked like chunks of EXP.

“Let’s wrap this up. Yeah?”

I crooked a finger at the wolf leading the pack in the distance. Judging by its size, that one had to be the leader.

- Grrrraaaah!

Since when did a wolf roar like a lion? Don’t tell me it was some kind of spiritual creature? Was I seriously going to lose to an animal?

Not happening.

I swallowed and raised my spear. I couldn’t afford to lose the battle of wills, so I glared hard and lowered my voice.

“Come.”

The effect was incredible!

- Grrrrr…

The charging wolf suddenly veered aside and plunged into the forest. Its dozens of subordinate wolves poured after it.

No—they had fled. A cold wind swept across the countless pawprints stamped into the snow.

What the hell?

They came running like they were going to eat me alive. Why run away?

Then a certain famous comic popped into my head. The one about a rubber man with hyperactivity disorder smashing the maritime authorities.

“D-don’t tell me it’s that?”

That ability that could terrify enemies—and even knock them unconscious—with qi alone.

This game was insane enough for it to be entirely possible. In which case, the System ought to ping me right about now…

Ding.

There it was! Buzzing with anticipation, I waited for the System voice.

Ignoring the reconnaissance squad members' bizarre expressions, I muttered over and over.

"Come on, come on, come on!"

It appeared.

The Quest Window.

SYSTEM

A Quest has been created.

Quest

Jopil, One Question, One Kill

The relentless chase has come to an end. You have come face-to-face with these cruel and tenacious pursuers, and you must confront Jopil, One Question, One Kill.

May you rest in peace... No, may fortune favor you in battle.

Grade: Peak

Limit: Jin Taekyung

Task: Survive — Incomplete

Reward: ???

Failure: Death

You do not have the authority to choose this Quest.

The Quest has been forcibly accepted!

"...Huh?"

What was happening? Where was I, and who was I?

Countless questions flashed through my mind and vanished. Then I heard someone's voice.

"We finally meet."

A man stood beside a gaunt tree, more than twenty zhang away.[103] Far if you called it far, close if you called it close. The problem was that none of us had known he was there.

Not even me.

When the hell did he...?

The higher my Level and martial realm rose, the sharper my five senses became. And yet I still hadn't detected that man. I hadn't even heard his footsteps.

If he hadn't spoken first—if the Quest Window hadn't appeared—I would have turned around without ever knowing he was there.

[103] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.03 m or 9.94 ft. Twenty zhang is about 60.6 m or 199 ft.

The wolves.

Those beasts had fled. Not from me, but from that man.

The unease that had plagued me since earlier finally took shape. I didn't even need to use Qi Sense.

I already knew his name.

"Jopil?"

The man—Jopil, One Question, One Kill—smiled broadly and nodded.

I had met three Peak masters so far.

Jin Wikyung, Wipeng, and the Head Elder. All three looked the part. Jopil, One Question, One Kill, did not.

He looks ordinary.

He wasn't a giant like Jin Wikyung, didn't have sharp eyes like Wipeng, and hadn't grown a silver beard like the Head Elder.

Jopil was of average height with an unremarkable face—and that made him look even more dangerous.

"Nice to meet you."

The instant Jopil smiled brightly and stepped forward, I sprang back without a second thought.

"Nimble. Good reactions, too. I like you."

My heart hammered. Maybe it was the tension, but my voice came out hoarse.

"Don't come any closer."

"Sorry about that. I was so happy to see you that I got carried away."

I wasn't happy at all.

"Don't be so tense. I only want to talk."

"Talk?"

"Yes. I've been wanting to meet you."

From Jopil's perspective, he probably had. He'd lost twenty men just a few days ago.

Fuck. I'm fucked.

The thought of a master like that chasing me day and night for two days just to tear me apart made my stomach turn.

"Don't give me that bullshit, Jopil!"

When I shouted, I felt the air freeze behind me. Jopil smiled as though he already knew what I was doing.

"What difference will telling them who I am make? Second Rate, Third Rate. They're all idiots and trash."

He'd read the reconnaissance squad's level exactly. I almost wondered if he was using the System too.

"Why don't we have a brief conversation? There's a great deal I want to ask you."

"A conversation? You're not just buying time?"

"Buying time? What do you mean?"

"You know what I mean. You're waiting for your men."

As if I'd hit the mark, the bridge of Jopil's nose twitched. Right. I didn't know why, but he was alone. If I was willing to take a few losses, it might be enough to…

"Waiting? Me? For those pathetic weaklings?"

"…What?"

"Didn't I already tell you? They're all idiots and trash. Hopeless lives without effort or talent."

"…"

"Black Mountain Blade was decent enough, but he had no eye for people, so he deserved to die. I ripped his eyes open before I left. Punishment for failing to recognize a master."

Correction. Jopil, One Question, One Kill, didn't merely look dangerous.

He was one fucking dangerous bastard.

This guy's completely insane.

I'd never met anyone like Jopil, either in real life or in a game. That utterly nonchalant tone and manner. He treated people like tools. A psychopath.

"Anyway, what you're worried about won't happen. They're painfully slow. It'll take them half a shichen to catch up.[104] By then, everything will be over."

One thing was certain. In the ending Jopil had in mind, his own death wasn't part of it.

"Well?"

"And if I refuse?"

Jopil smiled softly.

"I'll be disappointed in you. Very disappointed."

I could more or less picture what would happen if he was disappointed.

"Junior, I bear you no grudge. No—if anything, I'm rather fond of you. Answer a few questions truthfully, and I may even let you go."

"Wait. Let me go?"

"Yes. I won't harm you in any way. I'll send you back in one piece."

"…Really?"

"I'll stake my neck on it. Is that enough?"

[104] A shichen is a traditional time period of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Sincerity showed on Jopil's face. Unpredictable psychopath or not, maybe there was a chance we could all make it out alive.

"All right."

Even if the worst came, all I could do was fight. I'd buy a little time and try to read his openings.

"Good. A friend who listens to reason, hahaha."

Jopil clapped and laughed. The scabbard hanging at his left hip swayed.

Right-handed. Swordsman.

I continued filing away information in my head.

"First, I'd like to ask your age."

"Twenty."

Jopil's eyes widened.

"My. That realm at twenty. Impressive."

I'd spent seven years as a Hunter without ever escaping F-rank, yet here in the game, I was treated like a martial arts genius. It was a strange feeling.

"Judging by your clothes, you seem to be from the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

I nodded readily.

"Supreme First Rate at twenty. You wouldn't be that famous Heaven Shaking Sword, so… your name?"

"Jin Taekyung."

"Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung. I've heard that name somewhere. Ah!"

After mulling it over, Jopil exclaimed.

"The wastrel Third Young Master! That's you?"

"Not a wastrel. These days, they call me the Hidden Dragon."

"Puhahaha! I knew it. The straitlaced Jin Family of Taiyuan, resorting to poison? As if. I don't know who set all this up, but things are getting interesting."

Jopil regarded me with satisfaction.

"I'd already heard plenty of rumors about you. Was all of that a disguise?"

"…Something like that."

"Good. A hidden blade, then. I like it. When did you begin learning martial arts?"

"Seven years ago."

It wasn't entirely a lie. By Murim standards, a Hunter's combat methods were a kind of martial art too.

"Seven years. And your master?"

"Don't have one."

"No master?"

He studied me for a while, then said,

"Doesn't seem like a lie."

"You promised to spare me if I answered honestly. That was your promise, wasn't it?"

"Yes, it was. What an absurd yet fascinating story. A direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, with no master, reaching that realm at twenty… My, my."

My mouth was bone-dry. I gripped the spear and scanned Jopil's body. The openings on him right now were unbelievable. But was what I was seeing really all there was?

He could be baiting me into attacking first.

The thought went no further. Jopil suddenly burst out laughing.

"Hahaha! Good. I like it. I'll keep my promise."

He'd keep his promise?

The thing I'd thought impossible was actually happening. I stared at him blankly.

"No need to look at me like that. Truthfully, I wanted very badly to kill you at first… But now that we've met, I find myself wanting to watch you a little longer."

Jopil continued, his voice brimming with goodwill.

"It would be a shame to kill such outstanding talent. Especially under the current circumstances."

"What circumstances?"

"Ah, you may not know yet. You'll find out once you return. Go on, then. I hope you'll have grown a little more by the next time we meet."

I could go? He meant it?

I backed away without lowering my guard. Jopil merely watched me with a smile.

He looked like a fisherman releasing a minnow.

They say even if you enter a tiger's den, you'll survive as long as you keep your wits about you.

Who would have thought Jopil's unpredictability would become my way out?

Once I'd put a safe distance between us, the breath I'd been holding rushed out. But there was no time to catch it. I had to get out of there even one second sooner.

"We're moving. Hurry!"

Then—

"Hold on, Junior."

Jopil looked at me in puzzlement.

"What are you doing?"

"What do you mean? Going back, like you promised…"

"I only gave you permission to leave. Alone."

"…What?"

"I may not look it, but I'm in someone's employ. I have to complete the mission I was given."

The mission. Don’t tell me…

“The three survivors of the Sakju Branch. And those pieces of trash you call your subordinates. Leave them behind. I should be paid for two days’ work, don’t you think?”

His eyes, clear as a child’s, flashed. The next instant, they became the eyes of a predator.

“I’ll warn you now. If you refuse, I’ll be very disappointed.”

I stared blankly at Jopil, the reconnaissance squad, the young siblings, and the dying Gong Yacheong. There was little time, but my mind churned through the decision dozens of times before one answer finally burst out.

“Then be disappointed, you fucking bastard.”

Jopil laughed savagely.

Chapter 29

Some people never hesitate once they've made a decision. Jopil was one of them.

"Let's see what you've got."

With that casual remark, Jopil kicked off the ground. More than ten zhang vanished in two steps.[105] A flash burst from his waist.

Whoosh!

What the…?

My body moved before I could think. The instant my outstretched spear shaft met that flash—

Boom!

The impact hurled me backward with a thunderous crash. I flew toward the reconnaissance squad like a cannonball. Shields be damned—the three or four men at the front went down in a heap.

"Argh!"

"Captain! Are you all right?"

…Would I be all right?

Holy shit.

I gripped the spear shaft, which was still trembling from the impact.

The flash had been Jopil's sword. It was the fastest, strongest attack I had faced in all twenty-seven years of my life.

It hit that hard even though I blocked it?

If I'd reacted even a moment later, I would have been hiking up Mount Beimang by now.[106] I steadied my pounding heart and rose to my feet.

Jopil was smiling.

"I'm disappointed. Is that all you've got?"

The only reason I had been able to block it was because it was merely "that much." If I hadn't leveled up after mowing down those twenty men, I might already have been dead.

Fuck. Wrong opponent.

My realm was Second Rate. Even so, I had easily beaten two First Rate masters so far—with the martial arts and stats I'd gained through the System, and with the combat experience I'd accumulated.

But I could tell from that one attack.

This guy is different.

---

[105] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). More than ten zhang is more than about 30 meters (99 ft).

[106] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds; hiking up it means being dead.

I felt outmatched in every way. Jopil was on a completely different level from Lee Seogeun or Black Mountain Blade.

So different that the word *death* came to mind.

“You’re afraid.”

Afraid? Me?

I looked at my hand. The spear had stopped vibrating, but the hand gripping it was shaking like an aspen leaf. My heartbeat was so loud it felt as though everyone could hear it.

“How do you expect to survive the storms of the martial world with such a timid heart?”

Jopil clicked his tongue.

“This won’t do. Let me give you a little encouragement.”

“What?”

“Anger always overcomes fear.”

Before I could understand what he meant, Jopil flicked his sleeve. Several streaks of light shot out at once.

Danger!

The instant a red alert blared in my head, I swung my spear.

Clang!

Several throwing knives ricocheted away with a sharp ring.

But I couldn’t stop them all.

“Guh.”

One of the reconnaissance squad clutched his throat. Blood fountained between his fingers, and I saw a throwing knife buried there.

“Grrk. Cap… Captain. Grrk.”

He dropped to his knees, gurgling on blood. His still-boyish face was twisted with the terror of dying.

“P-please, save me…”

Whoosh! Thunk!

No one survived throwing knives to the throat and between the eyes.

Neither did he.

Splat.

He fell face-first onto the ground, which had only just begun to thaw, and never rose again.

It had all happened in an instant.

“I chose him because he looked the youngest… Was he a cherished subordinate?”

I shook my head.

“No.”

“That’s a shame.”

“I don’t even know his name.”

“And you call him your subordinate?”

“He’s an NPC. I don’t need to know his name or his age.”

“What?”

I rolled the corpse onto his back. After brushing the dirt and snow from his face, I closed his staring eyes.

Then, as if making a confession, I told the still-bewildered Jopil the truth.

“We only met three days ago.”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah.”

“Then…”

Jopil smiled as he continued.

“Why are you angry?”

He was right. Something was boiling up from the pit of my stomach. My head and chest burned so hot that I had to say something.

What was that kid’s name again?

He was Number Seven in the reconnaissance squad. I’d forced him to carry a shield even though he hadn’t wanted to, and I’d trained him whenever I got the chance. He was young enough that a few words of praise always made him grin from ear to ear.

What was his name?

I couldn’t remember.

I didn’t even know the names of everyone who lived in my goshiwon.[107] Why would I remember some NPC I’d only known for a few days? I had no reason to. No need.

But…

I was annoyed.

I was furious.

I’d thought things would be different in a game, but even here, I had failed to protect one of my teammates.

The whole reason I had trained him so hard, all the effort of the past few days—it had vanished like foam. I opened my mouth and breathed out hot air.

“You son of a bitch. You’re dead.”

I chewed and swallowed my last fasting pill.

A System message announced that my energy had recovered.

Boom!

[107] A goshiwon is a small, inexpensive rented room, typically in a building of similar rooms.

I kicked off the ground and launched myself forward.

Jopil knocked aside the spearhead surging up from his blind spot.

Clang! Skrrratch!

Fast and powerful. His fundamentals were solid, and he had a keen sense for combat.

He was beyond the likes of that brat from the Mount Heng Sword Sect or a rootless wandering martial artist like Black Mountain Blade.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan… Even rotten, a Chinese herring is still a Chinese herring, is that it?

Jopil leisurely slipped past the spearhead as he considered the young man before him.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan's decline was nothing new. The prestige that had once dominated Shanxi Province had long since faded. All that remained was the dim glory of the past and the rare talent that appeared once in a blue moon.

Someone like Jin Taekyung.

They've raised an interesting one.

Such skill at twenty. He was not yet a match for the Heaven Shaking Sword, who was already hailed as the greatest master in Shanxi Province, but he was certainly intriguing.

Age aside, his internal energy and martial arts were both middling… but he knew how to fight. He knew exactly when to retreat and when to advance, and whenever an opportunity appeared, he charged in like a fighting demon.

Just as he was doing now.

"Ha!"

Whoosh—Boom!

The spearhead flashed toward Jopil's face and pierced empty air. The explosive crack sent his hair flying.

Well, look at this.

Every motion from gripping the spear to thrusting it was compact and flowed seamlessly into the next. More striking still was the way Jin Taekyung smoothly twisted his entire body before releasing an explosive burst of force.

Silk-reeling force.[108]

It was still clumsy, but there was no mistaking it.

Silk-reeling force at twenty?

[108] Silk-reeling force is a method of twisting the body in a continuous, coiling motion to release power.

An innate feel for combat. Experience reminiscent of an old veteran of the martial world. And talent.

His potential was frightening.

Just as Jopil reached that conclusion, Jin Taekyung muttered with a stiff expression,

“Fuck, what the hell is this?”

“…”

Jopil stumbled over his own feet.

The instant he thought *ah, shit*, Jin Taekyung’s spear slid in like a snake. He hopped back and opened the distance, but the internal energy on that spear was no joke.

Riiip!

It was the first attack Jopil had allowed through. His robe split open in a long gash, baring his chest.

“Ah, so close. I could’ve finished it.”

“…”

So close? Finished it? Against me—Jopil, One Question, One Kill?

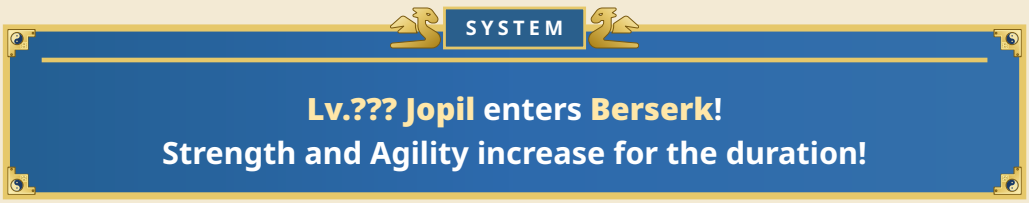
As Jin Taekyung smacked his lips in disappointment, Jopil felt rage surge through him.

“Youuu bastard!”

His shout, laden with internal energy, shook the forest. His eyes rolled back as he charged at Jin Taekyung.

The instant I sliced open Jopil’s robe, a System notification rang.

Ding.



Damn it. Even more?

“Graaaaah!”

Boom! Boom!

Blow after blow crashed down with a thunderous roar. The ground erupted, and trees were torn out by the roots.

With his eyes rolled completely white, Jopil rampaged like a madman.

The problem is, he’s no ordinary madman.

He was a madman who also happened to be a Peak master. If not for the **Gambler** Title, which increased my combat stats by ten percent in a one-on-one fight, I wouldn't have lasted this long.

Boom!

That wasn't martial arts.

It was a bombardment.

But Jopil's attacks had lost all precision. His movements were normally compact and fast, but the excessive strength from **Berserk** made them wider and left him full of openings.

I only need him to show me one…

The problem was, I couldn't find it.

He had completely lost his mind and was laying waste to everything around him. Dodging was all I could manage. Blocking was out of the question.

Step into range and I would be shredded. That much was obvious.

"Captain!"

"We're coming!"

I hurriedly waved off the reconnaissance squad members charging toward me.

"Hey, don't come over here! Don't come! Fall back!"

Had they lost their minds? Coming *here*?

We had already lost one man for nothing. I didn't want the entire reconnaissance squad wiped out.

Besides…

If those guys come over here, the Gambler Title's effect disappears!

Gambler only worked in a one-on-one fight.

I was barely hanging on as it was. If I lost the Title's effect too, I had no idea how much longer I could last.

"Get back, you bastards!"

I shouted and hurled myself sideways. Right on cue, Jopil's sword smashed the ground apart.

Crunch!

"Captain!"

Hyuk Mujin's shout came a beat too late. Despite my warning, he was already charging in. Behind him, I saw Han Yeop's grim, determined face.

"Hey, don't—!"

"Jopil, you vicious bastard!"

"Get away from the Captain!"

But they were already too late. Hyuk Mujin and Han Yeop, who had sprinted over with everything they had, thrust their weapons at Jopil while his attention was still on me.

"Die!"

Sword and spear. Spear and sword.

Their timing was excellent, and their attacks worked together as if they had practiced them beforehand.

There was only one problem.

They had the wrong opponent.

"How dare you, you rats!"

Jopil reacted instantly. He planted his sword in the ground, spun around, and struck both weapons with his bare hands.

Facing a sword and spear empty-handed was suicide.

But this was Murim.

More precisely, Jopil was a Peak master.

Crack—Crunch!

His palm merely brushed the side of Hyuk Mujin's blade, yet the sword shattered before it could even reach him. Han Yeop stared in horror at his own spear, its head sliced clean off.

That was the result of Jopil's rigid knife-hand.

"What the…"

"That's impossi—"

Before they could finish, Jopil slammed both hands into their chests.

They smashed into trees, spraying fountains of blood.

"I'll kill you."

The whites of his eyes had vanished from his chillingly smiling face.

Berserk had worn off. He had regained his senses.

"Fuck…"

One disaster after another. Mountains beyond mountains. Enemies on every side.

Jopil, you son of a bitch.

The situation kept spiraling toward the worst possible outcome. If anyone was going to stop him, it had to be me.

"Jopil—!"

The internal energy I drew up with all my strength raced through my body. I kicked off the ground and shot toward him.

Jopil grinned broadly.

"Right. I'll kill you first."

But I had one thing to count on.

He's empty-handed right now.

That was the mistake he'd made while Berserk. And I was certain I could end this before he pulled the sword from behind him and swung it.

In the next instant, I dragged up every last bit of internal energy in my dantian. I focused all of it into a single point—the tip of my spear—and thrust.

"Die!"

The final form of the Jin Family's Spear Technique.

Sky-Piercing Strike.

If it could pierce the heavens, why couldn't it pierce Jopil's heart?

I was certain.

This is… the end.

The world slowed, and I saw Jopil's face.

He was smiling.

The instant I saw that smile, I realized it.

Something was wrong.

Skrrrng!

Jopil's sword was faster than my spear.

The blood-soaked crimson blade shoved the spear shaft aside and drove inward.

The instant my spearhead, laden with internal energy, pierced empty air—

Slash!

A chilling sound rang out, and my chest suddenly felt cool.

Then came the searing pain and a burst of blood.

Fortunately, I had jerked back at the last instant and avoided a fatal wound.

Damn it.

What the hell had just happened?

As I staggered backward, Jopil rushed me.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Crimson sword-light poured down. Every flash was so fast and strong I could barely see it.

I gritted my teeth and swung my spear, but Jopil surpassed me in both momentum and martial arts.

Slash! Thunk! Splurt!

Lightning tore across my body. The blade stabbed my shoulder, slashed my knee, and pierced my side before pulling free in a spray of blood.

"Guh."

"You still haven't dropped your weapon. I'll give you that."

Jopil added,

"If you survive this too."

The next instant, his hand slammed into my chest.

Chapter 30

Whoosh.

The instant Jopil's red-hot palm struck my chest, lava-hot qi swept through me. My breath caught, and my internal energy surged backward.

What is this?

The question crossed my mind as I went flying. I bounced and rolled for more than ten zhang[109] before finally coming to a stop.

"Cough."

Blood trickled down my chin. Every so often, unidentified chunks came up with it. They were… fuck. Pieces of my organs.

He got me good.

Through my blurred vision, I saw Jopil walking toward me. His unhurried stride carried the ease of a victor.

I have to get up.

I groped beside me until my hand closed around a cool spear shaft. Using the spear as a cane, I barely managed to stand—and found Jopil staring at me with narrowed eyes.

"You can still stand after taking a Flame Divine Palm at seventy percent power… What a troublesome junior."

Wham!

Another palm strike slammed into me.

The Flame Divine Palm was every bit as powerful as its name. My shirt burned away, and my flesh melted and sloughed off. The heat that invaded my body tore through my meridians one after another.

"Guh."

Horrific pain crashed over me. Instead of writhing in agony, I thrust my spear at Jopil's vital point.

Thunk.

"You're like a fighting dog."

Jopil snatched the spear shaft and clicked his tongue.

"Someone at your level can't do anything to me."

"Go… fuck yourself!"

The next instant, I let go of the spear and threw myself into his chest.

This was my last chance. I focused every bit of internal energy into a single point. If I could strike one of his vital points, I could turn the tables.

But…

[109] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.33 meters (10.9 ft).

"Gasp."

The result was disastrous.

I had forced up my internal energy without regard for my internal injuries. I collapsed on the spot, trembling as if I'd been struck by lightning.

Drool ran from the corner of my mouth.

"Pfft. Puhahaha! Have you ever seen such a stupid bastard!"

Jopil howled with laughter and snapped off the spearhead.

"Well? What now? Huh? Youngest Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

Now I didn't even have a weapon. Despair darkened my vision.

Am I going to die like this?

In the past seven years, death had never felt this close. I had fought more than a thousand times and survived. Was I really going to die here, of all places?

This pointlessly?

No. I can't die like this…

I reached out, but that was as far as I got.

"Captain!"

A shout crackling with static was the last thing I heard before all light vanished.

When I opened my eyes again, I was in neither heaven nor hell. I was drenched in sweat and panting, my whole body as heavy as waterlogged cotton.

A dream? Or my life flashing before my eyes?

Whatever it was, one thing was certain. This was the past—a memory from seven years ago. The familiar face of the training instructor was proof enough.

"You… What did you…"

The instructor couldn't finish. He was staring at a steel training dummy modeled after a monster.

Now it looked more like scrap metal, bent and split all over.

"Was that a skill just now?"

My younger self answered in an exhausted voice.

"Thrust with All My Might."

"Thrust with All My Might?"

"Yes. I just thrust as hard as I could."

"You don't know how you're doing it, but you started using it naturally after you Awakened?"

"Uh, yes. That's right."

"That's a skill, you idiot."

Looking dumbfounded, the instructor turned to the file in his hand.

“Jin Taekyung. Twenty years old. Lives in Goyang, Gyeonggi Province. F-rank Awakened. Is this you?”

“Yes. So, my full-power thrust—no, my skill. It’s good, right?”

“You’re asking if it’s good?”

The instructor let out a hollow laugh.

“I’ve been at this training center for fifteen years, and I’ve never seen anything like it. That kind of destructive power shouldn’t appear below D-rank.”

“Fuck, I knew it. Instructor, I’m leaving.”

“What?”

“I’m going to get reassessed. Honestly, that should be enough for E-rank, at least.”

“No. I think they assessed you correctly.”

“What?”

“The skill itself is incredible. It’s far beyond anything an F-rank should be capable of. But…”

The instructor scratched the back of his head.

“You can’t use it.”

“Why? Why not?”

“Your body can’t keep up. That skill is beyond what F-rank mana and physical ability can handle. That’s why you collapse after using it once.”

“But I’m fine.”

“Are you?”

Before I could even nod, the instructor’s hand shot out like lightning and tapped me on the chest.

Literally just a tap. But I’d used up all my strength, so I toppled flat onto my back.

My whole body throbbed. I could barely move a finger.

“You’re already putting out more power than your body can handle. Eventually, it won’t end with a little soreness.”

“…Is there another way?”

“Solid fundamentals. Excellent technique. And your own combat sense. If you want to live a long life, don’t use that skill. Ah, except under special circumstances.”

“Special circumstances?”

The instructor grinned and added,

“When your life is in danger. That skill might save you once.”

The next instant, I opened my eyes on the cold snowfield.

“Captain!”

The last shout I'd heard now rang clear. So did the sharp pain from my mangled body.

I'm still alive.

My life had flashed before my eyes in a mere instant. Jopil had turned to look behind him, close enough for me to touch if I reached out.

"They're certainly loyal. Their skills are pathetic, though."

The reconnaissance squad was charging toward us in a cluster.

"I'm thinking of tearing them apart. What do you say?"

"…been fighting…"

"What?"

"Like an idiot… fighting…"

I mumbled again. Jopil bent down, irritation on his face.

"Can't you even speak properly?"

"I said I've been fighting like an idiot this whole time."

Ptoo!

The moment I'd been waiting for.

I spat the blood I'd gathered into his face. At the same time, my hand—already moving half a beat ahead—slammed down toward his foot.

Inventory Open.

Jopil didn't know.

I was a Hunter, a man of Murim, and a player who could use the System!

Equip Dagger.

A solid weight filled my empty hand. His face covered in blood, Jopil tried to jerk back, but the dagger had already punched through the top of his foot.

Shunk!

"Guh."

Even a Peak master was still human.

His body froze at the sudden pain. I released the dagger and reached for his ankle.

Equip Dagger.

My Inventory was piled with weapons taken from the enemies I'd killed since the Tutorial. Swords, spears, axes, daggers… more than twenty in all.

Jopil's men had been walking armories.

Slice.

"Gaaah!"

His Achilles tendon.

The instant I severed the tendon at his ankle, a scream burst from him. As his stance collapsed, I rolled aside, slashing and stabbing until his remaining left leg was soaked in blood as well.

Slice. Thrust. Thrust. Stab-stab-stab!

Jopil's mouth opened wide in rage and pain.

"Gaaaaah! You son of a bitch!"

Both his legs were useless, but Jopil was still a Peak master. He spun like lightning, slipped past my dagger, caught my wrist, and twisted.

Crack.

"Gah!"

His attack didn't end there.

A red-hot palm.

The Flame Divine Palm.

Boom.

My chest caved in. My vision went white as powerful fire qi tore through my body.

Boom.

The strength drained from me.

I heard the bones in my neck grind out of place under Jopil's grip. His chilling voice slid into my ear.

"Now you understand, don't you? Who you dared lay a hand on."

"…Cough."

"If King Yama[110] asks, tell him I sent you."

As I hung limp as a corpse, Jopil declared with rapture written across his face,

"Die."

His final Flame Divine Palm shot toward my chest. Lava-hot power capable of swallowing my life whole burned within that crimson palm.

And at last…

Tap.

The world stopped.

There was no lava. No heat of any kind.

Only his battered, callused palm resting against my chest.

A ripple ran through Jopil's eyes.

"You…"

The grip around my throat went slack. As Jopil staggered backward, I saw the dagger below his navel, buried deep in his dantian.

"What… What the hell is this?"

The next instant, blood ran down his chin.

That was only the beginning.

Blood began pouring from his eyes, nose, and ears as well—a waterfall streaming from all seven orifices.

[110] King Yama is a judge of the dead in East Asian Buddhist tradition.

The reconnaissance squad stopped in their tracks at the horrifying sight. Someone muttered as if groaning.

"Qi deviation…"

Internal energy was a double-edged sword.

I had waited for the moment Jopil drew his internal energy to its peak, then driven a dagger summoned from my Inventory into his dantian.

The result was a violent reversal of internal energy.

Qi deviation.

"You were definitely empty-handed."

I answered wearily.

"Live long enough, and all sorts of things happen."

"I can't die like this. This makes no sense."

Jopil muttered like a man who had lost his mind, stumbling forward one step at a time.

Pools of blood formed wherever he passed.

"I am Jopil. Jopil, One Question, One Kill. The nineteenth-generation successor of the Fire Gate Clan. I am not someone who should die at the hands of a nobody like you!"

A chilling, ghostly aura radiated from him as he screamed, drenched in blood. Even the reconnaissance squad members who had charged in ready to die trembled in fear.

"Then why? Why, at the likes of you, would I—!"

That was when the ember I'd thought extinguished burst into flame.

The change began in Jopil's body. His bleeding stopped, and blue veins bulged all over him. He looked as if he could no longer feel the pain of his severed tendons—or even the qi deviation.

Terrible heat poured from every breath.

What is this?

A literal resurrection?

No. This was Jopil's last desperate struggle.

Everyone around me screamed in terror, but I could see it clearly. His hair was turning white by the second. His skin was shriveling.

Right now, he was…

Burning away his life.

He means to kill me, at least, before he goes.

This was power gained by sacrificing the most precious thing he had, and every bit of it was aimed at me. I knew instinctively that I couldn't dodge.

Can I do this? Me?

I picked up the fallen spear.

The *Sharp Spear* I'd used ever since the Tutorial.

Its spearhead had been broken off. Now it was nothing more than a pointed iron rod.

I'll end up looking like this soon enough.

I had only one option left.

Even if it worked, there was no guarantee I'd survive. But I had no time to hesitate.

"Jin Taekyung!"

"Yeah. Let's finish this."

Me and Jopil.

Jopil and me.

We shot toward each other. The heat pouring off him melted the piled snow and dried my lips. I drew a long breath.

Sss. Hoo.

The noise around me receded. My heartbeat and breathing thundered in my ears.

Thump. Thump-thump. Thump-thump-thump.

My heartbeat reached its peak. My breathing fell into place with mechanical precision.

I knew.

Now.

At that instant, I awakened the internal energy in my dantian. Inside my body, where my qi and blood pathways lay twisted and ruined, only one source of internal energy remained.

The third, hardened like rock.

My only option—and the last piece that would fill my Skill.

Run wild as you please.

The awakened energy went berserk. It forced its way through my ruined pathways and surged throughout my body. Mind-numbing pain struck me.

But the new strength flooding through me soon made me forget it.

Go!

Every muscle in my body pulled taut. From my calves and thighs, through my waist and along my thrusting arm, every last bit of my strength and internal energy surged forward.

Condensed air burst from the broken spear tip.

Matching it, Jopil thrust out his Flame Divine Palm.

"Dieeeee!"

Whoooosh.

A mound of snow erupted with the wind. Through the flakes drifting gently back down, Jopil came into view.

His right arm, the one that had unleashed the Flame Divine Palm, was gone. So were his shoulder and side.

Half his upper body had evaporated.

“What kind of martial art…?”

I dropped the spear and answered.

“Thrust with All My Might.”

The next instant, heaven and earth flipped.

Beyond my blurring vision, Jopil’s already lifeless head shot high into the sky.

Socheon was crying out loud, holding a sword as tall as he was.

Chapter 31

“Well, look at you. Must be nice.”

I slowly opened my eyes to a familiar face.

“Did you come here for a picnic? Who sleeps in the middle of a Gate?”

I must have dozed off. I shamelessly denied it.

“I wasn’t sleeping. Who says I was?”

“Wipe the drool off your mouth before you start lying.”

“Tch.”

“Oh, you little—”

He shook a fist at me, but a smile tugged at the corners of his mouth. I rubbed my stiff neck.

“Ugh, I’m tired.”

“Did you meet a woman yesterday? Why are you nodding off like a sick chicken even in the middle of a raid?”

“When would I have time to meet a woman? You know my situation.”

“True enough.”

We’d been through thick and thin together for five years, ever since our first battle. He knew me as well as I knew him.

“Then what’s wrong?”

“What do you think? Money.”

“Money? Don’t tell me you’re moonlighting.”

His voice dropped. I looked past his shoulder at the team members resting nearby and nodded.

“Well, well. This bastard gets a little experience under his belt and starts lining his pockets on the side. And you call yourself the vice team leader.”

“Raids have been scarce lately, and I’m strapped. Really strapped. You’ve done it yourself, hyung[111], so don’t give me that.”

Hunters with professional licenses were legally barred from taking second jobs. A D-rank Hunter probably wouldn’t have to live like this, but F-ranks like us had no choice. The Guild knew how things were, so they looked the other way even when they found out.

“True, but… be careful. If someone files a complaint with the Management Agency, you’ll have a real mess on your hands.”

“It’s a trustworthy place. They pay cash the same day, so there’s no problem. You think I’d risk it otherwise?”

---

[111] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"Really?"

Judging by his expression, he was tempted.

"Do you need money too, hyung[112]?"

"I've got three kids. I need an oil well to spring up in my yard."

Misery filled his eyes as the words poured out. I'd already heard this routine dozens of times. After railing against the hardships of raising children, the rising price of formula, and the shamelessness of merchants, he patted me on the shoulder.

"Don't get married."

"I won't."

More precisely, I couldn't.

I had no woman and no money. My goal in life was to buy a house in a safe zone within five years, so deep down, I envied him.

A spouse I loved. Children. A happy family.

I had no idea when I'd ever have something like that.

"Marriage is a swamp."

For all his talk, he was famous for being a devoted husband and a good father. I knew he sometimes took out his family photos and smiled fondly at them.

"It sucks your whole life in. By the time you come to your senses, you're buried up to your chest and can barely breathe."

"…"

Maybe I'd had the wrong idea about him.

"So don't spend all your time working. Take breaks. Dating, hobbies—stuff like that's good for you."

"I don't know. I still need the money."

I scratched my head as I answered. He gave me a concerned look.

"I saw you sleeping earlier. You were drenched in cold sweat. Keep that up and you'll drop dead from overwork."

"Was I?"

Now that he mentioned it, my back was damp with cold sweat. I must have had a bad dream…

Can't remember.

Probably just some stupid dream anyway.

A Gate.

[112] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

These days, Gates provided a living for Hunters like me, but their true purpose was to serve as invasion routes for the armies of the Demon Realm.

When Demon King Asmodeus fell, his mighty army was routed with him. But even decades later, the Gates remained.

“Defensive formation!”

At his command, three Hunters carrying enormous tower shields blocked the path ahead. In a narrow cave, that alone was enough to stop most attacks.

Clang! Clang-clang!

“Giiiiik!”

Some twenty goblins hurled poison needles, axes, and spears, but every last one bounced off those big, beautiful tower shields.

“Archers!”

The tanks blocked every attack from the front while the archers rained arrows from the rear. As we pressed forward and took down nearly half of them, the goblins let out panicked shrieks.

“Gyaaaah!”

“Kieek!”

He gave the next order at exactly the right moment.

“Attack formation!”

The tanks dropped their tower shields and burst forward at the same time. I was faster.

“Hah!”

I swept the iron spear through a wide arc. Green blood burst into the air, and the front rank collapsed. I plunged into the gap, stabbing and slashing at everything within reach, and their formation crumbled.

“Charge!”

The damage dealers and tanks piled in. In moments, the goblin pack had become a heap of corpses.

“Pretty easy today, huh?”

“Honestly, the vice team leader did half the work. He was flying around out there. When did he get that good…? Shh. The Team Leader’s pissed.”

The team members chatting among themselves fell silent the moment he appeared.

“Hey, Jin Taekyung!”

That made me jump.

I’d been staring into space, lost in thought, and jerked in surprise.

“What?”

“Who told you to go off on your own? Are you a tank? Did you forget the attack order? And you still call yourself the vice team leader?”

"That's not—"

"If you're going to pull this kind of shit, transfer teams. You're putting everyone else in danger."

I looked at his grim face and sighed.

"I'm sorry. I don't know why I did that. They just… suddenly didn't seem like a big deal. I must have lost it for a second."

It was a strange feeling. The instant I saw the goblin pack, I thought I could wipe them all out by myself.

No, it hadn't been a thought.

It had been certainty.

"You…"

He swallowed whatever he had been about to say. We'd had each other's backs for five years, and this was the first time I'd ever done anything so reckless.

"Don't do it again. If something's bothering you, tell me."

He patted my shoulder and walked away. As I watched him go, something in my chest throbbed.

Should I see a doctor?

But it wasn't long before I stopped thinking about the pain altogether.

"Magic Gem!"

"Got one here!"

"Another!"

"It dropped! It dropped! It dropped!"

"Mom! Hayeon!"

Ah, that last shout was mine.

His face was flushed with excitement too as he muttered, "What the hell is all this…?"

Twenty Magic Gems of various sizes lay neatly arranged on the ground.

Magic Gems. They looked like red pebbles, but they were known as the flower of the Gate. These concentrations of magical power found inside monsters were a form of higher-dimensional energy—and the most valuable of all monster byproducts.

"At this rate, each one's got to be worth over a million won.[113]"

That came from the Team Leader, an E-rank Hunter who had survived ten years in this business. Everyone's eyes went glassy at the intoxicating sight.

"Is it normally like this?"

[113] One million won is about $710 or €650.

At the new recruit's question, everyone shook their heads emphatically.

"Absolutely not."

An F-rank Gate yielded one or two on average. Even with incredible luck, you wouldn't find five.

I was busy doing the math.

Twenty million won[114] from the Magic Gems alone, another five million won[115] for the byproducts and Equipment. Add all the various allowances and…

Fuck. How much is all this?

It was the biggest jackpot I'd hit since becoming a Hunter.

And the raid wasn't even over yet.

"How far have we come?"

"We're almost there. Turn right and the boss zone is just ahead."

The words *boss zone* made everyone's eyes light up.

It went without saying, but a boss zone contained a boss. The boss monster was the strongest monster in the Gate—and the one with the most expensive byproducts, Equipment, and Magic Gems.

What if we take down the boss monster too?

It would be a literal jackpot. The opportunity of a lifetime for an F-rank Hunter.

Everyone was beaming at the thought when he spoke.

"Wait. Let me think."

What the hell was he saying?

"What do you mean?"

"Think about it. Every monster we've encountered has been an ordinary goblin, but we've found this many Magic Gems? Something's wrong."

He sighed. His face was still flushed with excitement, but now uncertainty clouded it.

"I know how you feel. I do… but we've already made a fortune. Let's be satisfied with this and turn back."

Satisfied?

Now? After coming this far, he wanted to turn back?

I looked at the other team members. Some of them had fought alongside me for two or three years. Others were new.

Every one of them wore the same expression I did.

"I'm against—"

My breath caught.

Damn it. The chest pain again.

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[114] Twenty million won is about $14,000 or €13,000.

[115] Five million won is about $3,600 or €3,200.

I tried to continue, but no sound came out. Now my ears had started ringing too.

What is this?

The pain and the ringing grew worse. I dropped to my knees, gasping for breath.

Someone. Please, help me.

I grabbed someone's pant leg and clung to it.

It was him. The man who had looked after me like a brother—and like a father—for the past five years.

Hyung.[116] *Please save me.*

He looked down at me without emotion.

"Me? After you ran away and left everyone behind?"

What?

"I wanted to live too."

I forgot the pain and stared up at him. His clothes and skin melted away, exposing bone.

Everyone but me had become skeletons, sprawled across the ground.

Ah. That's right.

They had all died.

That day two years ago. In the boss zone I had insisted we enter, every one of them had died.

I was the only one who survived.

I floundered, drowning in the memories.

The ominous darkness hanging over the boss zone. The foul stench. The damp floor. That thing's enormous wings.

Bodies ripped to pieces in midair.

Terrified screams.

People running for their lives.

You fucking bastard!

But even the Skill I poured everything into wasn't enough to kill it. As I waited for death, he hauled me to my feet.

"Taekyung!"

"Hyung,[117] I'm sorry. It was all my fault."

If it hadn't been for me—if I hadn't gotten greedy—everyone could have survived.

They could have gone home to their families.

As I sobbed like a child, he forced himself to smile.

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[116] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[117] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“How is that your fault? Look at this kid. Now you’re even trying to play Team Leader.”

The massive body drifted through the cave. Stalactites rained down, and the last member of the team let out a death cry. In the darkness, its red eyes turned toward us.

“That arrogant bastard. Taekyung, go on ahead.”

“Hyung.[118] Cheonsu hyung!”

My chest hurt.

Pain surged through me, fierce enough to blot out my vision. It felt as though I had swallowed lava, as though everything inside me was burning away.

The ringing in my ears became a monster’s roar.

Kyaaaaau!

“Hyung[119]—!”

I woke with a scream.

But I wasn’t inside a Gate. There were no monsters and no team members.

Someone rose from beside the window, where sunlight streamed into the room.

“Were you dreaming about my lord? He’ll be pleased when I tell him.”

Coldness dripped from his face.

Wipeng, Jin Wikyung’s right-hand man.

The sight of him drove home the fact that I was still inside the game.

“Are you all right?”

“No. It was a nightmare.”

“Then I’ll leave that part out when I tell him.”

“Suit yourself.”

My entire body was drenched in sweat. Through the gaps between the bandages wrapped tightly around me, I could see skin crusted with scabs.

“How long was I out?”

“You were unconscious for five days. Your condition was so critical that the Medicine King Hall Master concluded you wouldn’t last the day.”

“Really?”

“Yes. When my lord heard, he flew into a rage. If I hadn’t stopped him, he would have beaten the Medicine King Hall Master to death.”

“Ah.”

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[118] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[119] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

I remembered the old man from the meeting a few days ago—the one who had threatened to drive a giant needle into the White Tiger Hall Leader's anus.

So he'd practically been praying for me to die.

"Did anything else happen?"

"A great deal. Among it all, there is good news and even better news. Which would you like to hear first?"

"The good news."

"First, the reconnaissance squad and the survivors of the Sakju Branch returned safely. Two of them suffered fairly serious injuries, but neither is in danger of dying."

Survivors.

The word made my heart drop.

Number Seven.

I remembered his face as he gasped out his final breath, one dagger lodged in his throat and another between his brows.

He couldn't have been more than twenty.

Far too young to die.

"Are you thinking about the dead?"

"The body—did they recover the body?"

"We recovered and buried him properly. He was an orphan with no family in the world, so there were no relatives to notify."

"…"

"May I say something?"

Wipeng didn't wait for my answer. He took a step toward me and continued.

"Third Young Master, do not turn your subordinate's death into a dog's death."

"What does that…"

"Martial artists are not beings meant to be protected. They are people who fight their enemies and prove themselves. He died facing an enemy too strong to do anything about, but that was not mere death—it was death in battle."

The notion that dying on a battlefield somehow made it an honorable death was the biggest load of bullshit I had ever heard.

There was no such thing as an honorable death.

Even now, I could vividly hear the screams of my comrades who had died two years ago. I could still see Number Seven's wide-open eyes as he breathed his last.

"The fact that he's dead hasn't changed."

"I have seen people obsess over facts that can never be changed. I won't name anyone."

"…"

"Do you regret it?"

“Of course.”

“Then live enough for him as well.”

Wipeng continued in a gentler voice than I had ever heard from him.

“I am not telling you to forget the dead. Bury them in your heart and carve them into your mind. Use that regret as your foothold, then soar to the place they dreamed of reaching. That is the path you must walk, Young Master.”

The path I must walk…

Just hearing those words made something in my chest lurch. I turned them over for a while, then let out a sudden laugh.

“Damn. I’ll break a leg before I get there.”

“It will take a lifetime.”

“If I devote my whole life to it, will I make it?”

“I don’t know. I don’t even know where my own path will end, so how could I know yours?”

“What’s waiting at the end of your path, Great Hero Wipeng?”

“The greatest under heaven.”

A joke?

No. Wipeng was more serious and resolute than I had ever seen him.

“That’s a hard one.”

“Because it is a dream.”

He was right. Dreams were always difficult to achieve.

All the more so when you carried the dreams of those you had lost.

“Great Hero Wipeng. May I ask you one thing?”

“Anything.”

“That guy. What was his name?”

“His name was…”

The moment Wipeng’s lips parted, a cold winter wind rattled the window.

Whoooosh.

Beyond the chill howl of the wind, I heard Number Seven’s name.

“That’s a great name.”

“I heard he chose it himself. His dream was every bit as grand.”

“What was it?”

“To become the greatest of all time.”

“…”

“You’ve got your work cut out for you.”

“Tell me about it. That’s ridiculous.”

A laugh escaped me. Only then did I feel the weight in my heart lift.

It was all thanks to Wipeng.

“You’re finally back to your old self.”
“Thank you.”
“Don’t mention it.”
Wipeng tipped his head and spoke.
“Now, there is still the even better news.”
Ah. Right.
Good news and even better news.
I waited eagerly to hear what he would say next.

Chapter 32

"There was a major battle two days ago. One hundred elite fighters from our family clashed with two hundred vanguard troops from the Mount Heng Sword Sect in Honju."

"There was a battle?"

And a major one, no less—hundreds of people thrown in. My heart lurched for a moment, but then I remembered what Wipeng had said earlier.

Good news and even better news. He'd already given away the outcome.

"We won."

"It was a great victory. Fewer than thirty of them escaped alive. That's about the same as our family's total casualties."

Judging by the scar running from Wipeng's forehead to his chin, it must have been a fierce battle.

Well, of course. They outnumbered us two to one.

Still, it was a relief we'd won. From the Jin Family of Taiyuan's perspective, we'd poured in nearly half our strength. If we'd lost, the damage would have been enormous.

"It's unfortunate that we let the Mount Heng Sword Sect's Lesser Family Head escape, but taking down the Mount Heng Twin Devils was a major gain."

"The Mount Heng Fucking Devils?"

"The Mount Heng Twin Devils. They were Peak masters under the Mount Heng Sword Sect, and their loyalty was something else… They kept throwing themselves at us without regard for their lives, so we had no choice but to kill them."

Wipeng tapped the fresh scar on his face.

"If we'd captured them alive, we could have extracted valuable information."

"Did you—I mean, did Great Hero Wipeng kill them?"

"My lord and I took one each. They were pretty good."

"…"

I was left speechless as Wipeng slurped his tea.

For fuck's sake… Are Peak masters a joke to him?

That had been the fiercest fight of my twenty-seven years. I'd suffered every kind of internal injury and been carved up like a steak. Then I'd been unconscious for five days, so I'd practically taken a half-bath in the River Jordan.[120]

And after taking down Peak masters of that caliber, all he had to say was that they were *pretty good*?

This guy's a complete monster.

[120] In Korean, "crossing the River Jordan" is a euphemism for dying; Taekyung twists it into taking a half-bath.

I learned something for certain this time: even Peak masters came in different levels. It was a huge relief that people of that caliber were on my side.

"That aside…"

Clink.

Wipeng set down his teacup and regarded me with an unreadable look.

"You were remarkable."

"Pardon?"

"I'm talking about Jopil, One Question, One Kill. Even calling it remarkable doesn't do justice to what you accomplished by defeating him."

"…"

You people seem a lot more remarkable to me.

It felt like being praised by an A-rank Hunter for being good at killing goblins.

"Ah. Right. Thanks, I guess."

I wanted to end the discussion about Jopil there. I was in lousy shape, my mood wasn't much better, and I wanted to check all the System Rewards waiting for me.

Let me rest already. I'm still a patient, damn it.

I tried to convey that with a wink. Wipeng frowned.

"Does your eye hurt? Shall I call a physician?"

"…No. I'm fine."

"Your eye just spasmed."

"That wasn't a spasm."

"It was. I saw it clearly."

"No, what I just did was…"

Then Wipeng rolled his eyes back until only the whites showed and started to tremble.

The table shook, and tea sloshed over the rim of his cup. I cried out in alarm.

"My God, Great Hero Wipeng!"

This guy has epilepsy. No—how does a Peak master even get epilepsy?

Just as I hurriedly tried to stand, the convulsions stopped. Wipeng returned to normal and spoke with perfect calm.

"That's what you did."

"Are you all ri—wait, what?"

"That's what you did just now, Third Young Master. Your eye spasmed."

"So you were imitating me?"

"Yes."

What kind of lunatic is this…?

I tried to explain the difference between a wink and an epileptic fit, but the words stuck. Wipeng was glaring at me like a pissed-off dictator.

"…Why don't we just finish talking about Jopil?"

"Let's."

Wipeng nodded in satisfaction.

Crazy bastard.

In the end, I had to tell him everything about my fight with Jopil from beginning to end.

How Jopil had moved. What martial arts he'd used. Wipeng's incisive questions had me tensing up more than once.

"You severed the sinews and meridians in Jopil's legs with a dagger?"

"Yes. I'd hidden it beforehand."

"There's no way Jopil would have failed to notice it… Continue."

When the long story finally ended, Wipeng released the breath he'd been holding. The complicated look in his eyes said more than words could.

"Third Young Master, you have accomplished a truly great deed."

"Ah, thank you…"

"I hate to admit it, but I mean that."

"…Ah. Right."

"When I think of all the trouble you've caused until now, my blood boils, but I was genuinely impressed. I mean that."

"…"

"Who could have imagined that the Third Young Master who stole family funds day after day and poured them into pleasure houses, then paraded through the streets dead drunk and smeared shit all over the family's reputation, would become such a great man? I, Wipeng, am genuinely in awe."

Just curse me out, you bastard…

I barely held back the torrent of abuse threatening to burst out.

"I got lucky. Jopil let his guard down too."

Wipeng shook his head.

"No. It was all skill. It makes no difference who let their guard down or who hid a dagger in advance. If that alone had been enough to kill Jopil, he would never have been Jopil, One Question, One Kill. Murim is a place where only the strong survive."

"Only the strong survive."

I quietly rolled the words over my tongue. They tasted somehow bitter and sweet at once.

Murim—this game—had been that kind of place from the beginning. I had survived there, and I had grown stronger.

“Jopil used every martial art at his disposal to its fullest. In the end, he even drew upon his innate qi. A Peak master threw away his own life in an attempt to kill you. But what was the result?”

“I won.”

“Yes. Exactly.”

“Then I was stronger than Jopil.”

Wipeng, who had looked vaguely displeased all this time, suddenly turned dead serious.

“What are you talking about? Jopil was stronger. Do Peak masters look like a joke to you?”

“…”

“You were only strong enough to kill Jopil with a surprise attack.”

Enough already. Seriously.

While I was debating whether to pull a weapon from my Inventory, Wipeng let out a short chuckle. It was the first time I had ever seen him laugh.

“Well done.”

I looked at Wipeng suspiciously.

“What are you going to add this time?”

His smile deepened.

“I mean it. It’s true I disliked you quite a lot, but… this time, I have no choice but to acknowledge you.”

When he put it that way, I had nothing to say. For some reason, I felt embarrassed and cleared my throat.

“Ahem. Well, I nearly died, but all I really did was take down Jopil and a few wandering martial artists. Ahem.”

“How many Peak masters do you think there are in a single city? Even across all of Shanxi, where our family is based, there are fewer than twenty.”

Twenty. Far fewer than I’d expected.

“The Mount Heng Sword Sect must have taken serious losses. They lost three Peak masters like that.”

“But the greatest blow lies elsewhere.”

“What is it?”

“That would be…”

The instant Wipeng opened his mouth, a trembling voice came from the doorway.

“Their pretext. They’ve lost the pretext they used to start this war. The Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan is more than strong enough without resorting to poison. Yes, indeed.”

The enormous Jin Wikyung stood in the doorway, teary-eyed and holding both arms wide open.

“My youngest!”

“…”

Please, just leave me alone.

In the end, I had to replay the chase of the past several days and my battle with Jopil all over again.

“The wandering martial artists who pursued the survivors…”

“Those bastards! I’ll tear them apart!”

Boom!

“Jopil’s Flame Divine Palm left me with internal injuries…”

“I’ll kill him! How dare that vicious wandering martial artist bastard! Even if I ripped out his guts and chewed them to a pulp, it wouldn’t be enough!”

Boom! Boom! Boom!

“…”

I stared blankly at the ruins of my bedroom. This was what Jin Wikyung’s excessive immersion in the story had wrought.

Wipeng had already backed far away and was mouthing something.

—It would be best not to bring that story up again.

For the first time, the two of us were in complete agreement.

Jin Wikyung huffed and puffed for a long while before finally calming dow—

“If that bastard had still been alive, he wouldn’t have died peacefully.”

Crunch.

I watched with sad eyes as the corner of the bed crumbled into powder. Wipeng shook his head.

“My lord. Please calm down. The Young Master seems anxious.”

That one actually worked. Seeing me sitting there sadly, wrapped in bandages from head to toe, Jin Wikyung’s eyes reddened.

“Just look at my youngest. How much must this poor child have suffered to be sitting there so completely out of it?”

Grab!

A hand the size of a cauldron lid clamped onto my shoulder and pulled me in. I was a fairly big guy myself, but this man was practically a small ogre. Trapped against his broad chest, I trembled in fear.

“There, little brother. It’s all right now. It’s all right.”

After a heartfelt hug that only he found moving, Jin Wikyung sniffed.

“I thought you’d be a child forever… but you’ve grown up now. Wipeng, did you know?”

Wipeng answered without even pausing to breathe.

“Yes. You don’t need to tell me.”

Of course, Jin Wikyung pretended not to hear him.

“Rumors have spread throughout our family and even through the streets. The tale of the hero who led a death squad in a raid on the enemy camp, defeated Jopil, One Question, One Kill, and one hundred wandering martial artists, and rescued the Sakju Branch’s household.”

“Wow. That’s amaz—wait, what?”

I blinked.

Hold on. That was my story?

“Um, I think there’s been some kind of misunderstanding.”

“That’s right, my lord. There seems to have been some misunder—”

Jin Wikyung smiled with satisfaction.

“Our little brother is modest, too. Wipeng, you shut your mouth.”

“No, it isn’t modesty. I think the rumor has been distorted a little.”

“That’s right. I know you care for the Young Master, my lord, but this is going too far. If the rumor gets too far-fetched, people won’t beli—”

“Rumor? Outlandish?”

BOOM!

Wipeng’s voice vanished beneath a thunderous crash. My mouth fell open as I stared at the gaping hole in my bedroom wall.

What the hell are you doing, you lunatic?

Jin Wikyung threw another punch. With a sound like compressed air bursting, what was left of the wall came down.

Wood and bricks poured from the two-story pavilion, sending the people outside into an uproar.

“It’s the Third Young Master! The Third Young Master’s residence is collapsing!”

“Get people over here! Hurry!”

While everyone was still reeling in shock, Jin Wikyung hoisted me into the air.

Put me down. Put me down, you crazy bastard!

I struggled with all my strength, but there was no fighting him off. One step. One step. Every step toward the gaping wall sent terror through me.

He’s going to drop me!

More than fifty people had gathered below. They called it a two-story building, but the pavilion was so large that we had to be a good ten meters[121] up. The wind gusting through the hole made me dizzy.

If I fall, that’s a fracture at the very least.

[121] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

Even as a chill ran down my spine, more people kept crowding in. Over fifty of them craned their necks to stare up at us.

“Who’s that? Wasn’t there an accident?”

“Isn’t that the Lesser Family Head? Who’s he holding?”

“The Third Young Master! It’s the Third Young Master!”

Someone’s shout sent a stir through the crowd.

“The Third Young Master—no, the Third Young Master, sir?”

“The Third Young Master who defeated Jopil, One Question, One Kill, has awakened!”

What is this situation?

While my eyes and ears were still whipping around, a solemn voice rang out clearly.

“Can you see?”

“Ah, yes. I can see them. Could you put me down—”

“Can you hear?”

“I can hear them too, but first, could you—”

“What do you feel?”

“Embarrassment. And shame.”

“They believe in you. They’re calling your name!”

“No, you fucking bastard.”

My final curse vanished beneath the crowd’s shouts.

“Third Young Master! Third Young Master!”

Dozens more people had appeared in that brief span of time. Countless gazes flew toward me and pinned me in place.

No, what is this?

Then Jin Wikyung, his expression grave, slid his hands beneath my armpits and lifted me high.

Right on cue, a thunderous cheer erupted.

“Woooooo!”

“Third Young Master! Jin Taekyung!”

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

And then…

Fuck. What is this, a baby lion?

The theme music from an old cartoon began playing in my head.

Chapter 33

“Please kill me.”

A young man with disheveled hair, covered in blood and dust, dropped to his knees. His name was Lee Seogwang—the elder brother of the late Lee Seogeun and the Young Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

“Report. Tell me yourself.”

The cold voice froze everyone inside the tent. Every last one of them was a senior of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, a master who had spent long years roaming the martial world.

Yet even they had to bow their heads before one man.

“Father…”

“That isn’t the answer I want.”

The Blood Wolf Sword, Lee Cheonbaek, did not even turn around. Lee Seogwang forced the words out in a trembling voice.

“There are only twenty-three survivors, including me. We don’t know whether the rest are alive or dead.”

A heavy silence settled over the gathering.

Some two hundred troops had been killed or captured, and they had lost three Peak masters. That alone would have made it difficult to escape punishment, but there was an even greater problem.

“What orders were you given?”

“…To wipe out the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s branch and advance as far as Jeongyang.”

“And after that?”

“To blockade the road and wait for the main force to join us.”

“Why did you push as far as Honju?”

“I received… intelligence.”

“Intelligence?”

“Yes. I was told that Jopil, One Question, One Kill, had pursued Jin Taekyung all the way to Honju and captured him. But…”

“He must have said the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s pursuit party was on his heels and asked you to help him.”

Lee Seogwang lowered his head, and Lee Cheonbaek let out a hollow laugh.

“Who delivered that information?”

“A wandering martial artist under Jopil.”

“Do you still believe it?”

“…No.”

Smack!

Lee Seogwang's head snapped to the side. Lee Cheonbaek glared down at him, his eyes blazing.

"Be grateful you were born my son."

In the end, Lee Seogwang was ordered to return to the Mount Heng Sword Sect. Once he withdrew, the matter was settled for the time being.

Now it was time to assess the situation with a cool head.

"What is our current position?"

"We lost two hundred men, but more than half were wandering martial artists we scraped together in a hurry. The damage isn't as severe as it sounds. The problem is…"

"We lost three Peak masters."

The thought left a bitter taste in Lee Cheonbaek's mouth. The Mount Heng Twin Devils had stood beside him for twenty years, and Jopil, whom he had paid a fortune to hire, was dead as well.

A Peak master could change the course of a battle. Somehow, they had to fill the void.

"Gather more. Buy wandering martial artists from the black market, hire mounted bandits—use whatever means necessary."

"Our expenses are already too high. By now, word of what happened in Honju will have spread, and they'll try to raise their prices."

"They aren't trustworthy men, either. Especially the mounted bandits. Aren't they human butchers? If we hire people like that, our sect's reputation will suffer afterward…"

Lee Cheonbaek did not even blink.

"All the better. Hire every last one."

"Sect Leader!"

"There are no fewer than five hundred men gathered here. We have more than twice their numbers, and we aren't outmatched in Peak masters either."

"My son thought the same thing. Then he got utterly crushed in Honju."

"That was…"

"I don't care whether they're human butchers or anything else. Throw everything we have into this. If we lose this war, it won't be our reputation we lose—it'll be our lives!"

At Lee Cheonbaek's thunderous command, the seniors realized there was no point trying to persuade him. But the discussion was not yet over.

"The martial artists' morale is in shambles."

"The defeat at Honju is bad enough, but the news that Jin Taekyung killed Jopil, One Question, One Kill, has shaken them."

Jin Taekyung.

Hearing his enemy's name made Lee Cheonbaek's stomach churn.

Are there really people stupid enough to believe such an absurd rumor?

As if it weren't enough that the pathetic fool Jin Taekyung had poisoned his son, now he had supposedly killed a Peak master as well. The scheme was obvious. Lee Cheonbaek ground his teeth at the Jin Family of Taiyuan's despicable tactics.

"Root out everyone spreading that nonsense. Don't let a single one escape!"

Taking a few heads as examples might lower morale even further, but it would keep the army from collapsing. Now was the time to clamp down and press forward.

"Three days. In three days, we march on Taiyuan!"

That was the nature of gratitude and grudges in Murim. The cycle would not end until one side fell.

I'll take everything from you. Just as you did.

"What an incredible recovery."

The physician clicked his tongue in amazement. It was my second day since waking up, and overnight, the scabs had fallen away to reveal smooth new skin beneath them.

"In ten years as a physician, I've never seen anything like this."

Even to me, the speed of my recovery was astonishing. The flesh melted by the heat of the Flame Divine Palm, the fractured bones, the deep sword wounds—there was no trace of any of them left.

Oh, and the internal injuries too.

Must be the effect of leveling up.

There was only one way to produce a similar result in the real world: the healing magic used by the tiny handful of Hunters known as healers.

Is complete healing too much to ask?

I was a little disappointed, but it was probably for the best. If a single level-up had healed every injury on my body, avoiding suspicion would have been difficult.

Even now, the physician kept glancing at me as though I were a monster.

"Heavens. How strange. This is far too much to attribute to the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng…"

"Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng?"

I remembered seeing something like that in martial arts novels. Ginseng that had grown for a hundred years, or whatever.

Why is that suddenly coming up?

Seeing my confusion, the physician explained. He was one of the few NPCs who knew I had lost my memory.

“Around this time last year, the Medicine King Hall’s storeroom was robbed.”

Ah. The moment he said it, I knew where this was going.

The stolen medicinals must have included the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng, and the culprit was obviously…

“The Medicine King Hall Master was absolutely furious.”

The physician gave me an awkward smile.

“After all, it isn’t something you can obtain merely by having money. You stole and consumed an elixir capable of granting twenty years of internal energy in a single dose.”

“Twenty years of internal energy?”

Something clicked. That third reserve of internal energy that had refused to obey me.

So that was it.

At the same time, a pang of regret hit me. When I used the Skill at the last moment, most of the twenty years of internal energy from the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng had vanished.

It had been a complete disaster caused by the energy running wild instead of obeying my control.

I blew the whole thing like a one-use item.

The physician misread my grimace and hurriedly added, “Of course, Young Master, you must have had some grand purpose in making such a decision.”

Grand purpose, my ass. I probably ate it as a tonic.

The snow ginseng’s internal energy had kept me alive, but it still felt like a terrible waste.

Such a waste I could die.

“You’ve almost completely recovered, so you shouldn’t have any trouble moving around. Then I’ll be on my way.”

The moment the physician hurried out, I opened the System window.

Open Status Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 30 Jin Taekyung
Class: Second Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 410
Titles: 4 (Title effects active)
— **Scion of a Prestigious Family** (All stats +5, Fame +50)
— **Family Shame** (All stats −5, Fame −50)
— **Novice Trainee** (Training speed +10%)
— **Gambler** (Combat-related stats increased by 10% in a one-on-one fight)
Strength: 115 **Stamina:** 120
Agility: 116 **Intelligence:** 15
Charm: 15 **Internal Energy:** 15 years
Remaining Points: 0

Pride welled up the moment I saw it.

I've come a long way.

It felt like only yesterday I'd been shaking in front of a few two-bit bandits. Now I was a master in my own right. My Level had shot up after I took down Jopil, and I'd gained a massive amount of Fame.

That wasn't all. By absorbing some of the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng's remaining energy, I had gained another four years of internal energy. And on top of that…

SYSTEM

Skill Window
One Annihilation
Grade: Peak
Realm: Second Stage
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Effect: Consumes Stamina and internal energy to deliver a powerful strike. Depending on the amount used, the user enters a helpless state for a certain period of time.

I had gained a new martial art—or rather, a new Skill.

But it differed greatly from my Skills in the real world.

I can control how much it consumes and how much power it releases.

Thrust with All My Might. The Skill now named One Annihilation couldn't be used recklessly. It could unleash destructive power several stages above my usual level for an instant, but that single attack consumed all my strength.

No. Maybe the Skill could always be controlled like this.

In the real world, I was an F-rank Hunter. My physical abilities were pathetic, and so was the amount of mana in my body. But here in this game—in Murim—I was different.

Here, I was a martial artist with fifteen years of internal energy and physical abilities superior to NPCs twenty or thirty Levels above me. With a better vessel to contain the power, I could finally use the Skill the way it had always been meant to be used.

I've gotten stronger again.

It felt like only yesterday Hyuk Mujin had been wiping the floor with me while I struggled to learn martial arts. Now I had taken down a Peak master.

Outside the window, people chanted my name several times a day.

Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. Hero of the family. That sort of thing.

A hero.

I never thought I'd hear anyone call me that. I was a two-bit F-rank Hunter whose motto was safety first. The word had never had anything to do with me.

I lay still and fidgeted with my hands. Palms that had once been a young master's —white and soft—were now packed tight with calluses.

I took down Jopil with these hands.

All told, the people I'd taken down numbered more than a few dozen. Bandits, wandering martial artists, even people rated as First Rate—and I had survived. I'd even taken down a Peak master I thought I could never beat: Jopil, One Question, One Kill.

Something Wipeng had said suddenly came back to me.

The one who survives is strong.

If he was right, then I was undeniably strong. I had survived every enemy I had faced so far, and now people were calling me a hero.

Yeah. If I was being honest…

It doesn't feel bad.

The real-world me was pitiful.

I ate and slept in a goshiwon[122] room barely ten square meters in size,[123] the breadwinner responsible for supporting my family. I couldn't become a hero, and I didn't want to.

---

[122] A goshiwon is a building that rents out small, inexpensive rooms, often with shared facilities.

[123] Ten square meters is about 108 square feet.

I was just Jin Taekyung, a bottom-rung Hunter who fought every day while praying he would survive.

That was me.

But in this game, I'm different.

I had accomplished many things that F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung never could. At the very least… I could protect the people who trusted and followed me from their enemies. People acknowledged me. They called me a hero.

Even if everything here was nothing but virtual, even if the people I saw were NPCs, that fact didn't change.

Thinking that, I suddenly laughed.

This is why games are scary.

Was this what game addiction felt like?

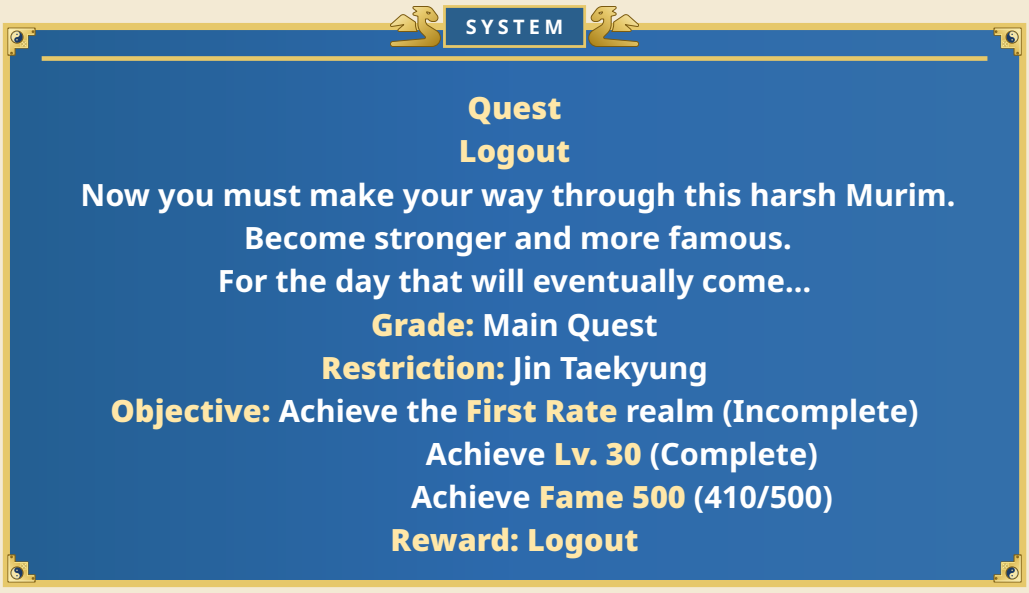
Before I knew it, I had started enjoying life as Jin Taekyung, a martial artist of Murim. This place was a game. It could turn every impossibility into a possibility.

But now it was time to leave.

Back to that place filled with impossibilities—the real world. My family was there. The real me was there.

Check Quest Window.

Ding.



Logout.

The moment I saw those four glittering characters, my breath caught.

Only two conditions left before I could log out. Time could take care of Fame. The more rumors about me spread, the more it would keep climbing.

The problem lay elsewhere.

"First Rate."

What did I even need to become First Rate?
If it wasn’t Level, stats, or Fame, then…
Internal energy? Or do I need to raise the realm of my martial arts further?
Just then, a polite voice came from outside the door.
“Young Master. The Lesser Family Head is looking for you.”
“Ah.”
Right. When you don’t know something, the best thing to do is ask.
And in that respect, Peak master Jin Wikyung was the best private tutor I could ask for.

Chapter 34

Once, while Jinho hyung[124] and I were watching TV, we had a conversation like this.

“That’s him, right? Han Seongjin.”

“You know Han Seongjin?”

“Wouldn’t it be weirder if I didn’t? His face is everywhere whenever I turn on the TV. I’ve seen him so often, he feels like family.”

“Watch your mouth. That’s defamation.”

“Son of a bitch.”

On the screen, a handsome man with a lanky build was smiling brightly. Dozens of cameras and a huge crowd reacted to his every move. Flashes and screams kept going off without a pause.

“He’s got everything. An A-rank Hunter is basically a walking mid-sized company, isn’t he? And he gets a model’s proportions and a celebrity’s face on top of that? That’s just cheating. How old did you say he was?”

“I think he’s the same age as me.”

“…Hang in there.”

No matter the profession, some people made good money and others didn’t. And no profession had a wider gap between the two than Hunters.

“Don’t worry, man. If you wait a little longer, your day will come.”

“How long do I have to wait?”

“Try waiting another hundred years. It’ll be possible in your next life.”

I wished I could show Jinho hyung[125], who had cackled as he mocked me back then, what I looked like now.

I wonder what kind of face he’d make if he saw this.

With every step I took, dozens of people swarmed after me. NPCs from the Jin Family of Taiyuan, men and women of all ages, were looking at me with shining eyes.

Is this how famous people feel all the time?

All that attention, all those admiring looks—it was a burden, but it also felt kind of good.

For the first time, I understood that clichéd line from game ads: *A new hero awaits!*

Yeah. It’s almost over. I might as well enjoy it.

I smiled and waved, and a roar went up. With the ever-growing crowd trailing behind me, I arrived at the main hall used for meetings.

“They’re waiting for you.”

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[124] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[125] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

The martial artist at the door looked familiar. He was the same man who had stared at me with contempt when Lee Seogeun came to visit.

Has it been about fifteen days?

Just as I was no longer the person I had been then, neither was he. He gave me an extremely respectful fist-and-palm salute and opened the door wide.

The main hall looked exactly as I remembered it. A large table stood in the center, and the chairs scattered on either side showed that a meeting had just ended.

"You're here?"

Seated at the head of the table, Jin Wikyung gave me a weary smile. He was alone in the spacious hall.

"Where's Wipeng?"

"He'll be back shortly."

Once I sat down, Jin Wikyung got straight to the point.

"The Lower District Sect has contacted us. The Mount Heng Sword Sect is gathering every last fighter it can."

They must be shitting bricks over there.

I didn't know war, but I knew fighting. And war was made up of battles. The enemy had already lost many martial artists and suffered a crushing blow to its morale. They would throw everything they had into the next battle.

"It'll be a difficult fight."

"They've poured their sect's entire wealth into it. If the reinforcements join the main force led by the Blood Wolf Sword, they'll number around a thousand."

"A thousand…"

That was an insane number. I had never fought in a battle on that scale, and I had no desire to.

Jin Wikyung continued grimly.

"We'll march north with all our forces and strike the enemy's main force before it can join the reinforcements."

"When?"

"In two days."

Goddammit. That's fucking fast.

The race against time wasn't only between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect. I was in one too.

Can I log out by then?

If I reached First Rate within two days, I could log out. But if I didn't, I would have to fight my ass off all over again.

Then I'd be completely screwed.

Jin Wikyung spoke again.

"I'd like you to take charge of the rear guard."

Can't. Won't.

I barely swallowed the words that tried to leap out on reflex.

Jin Wikyung looked more serious than I had ever seen him.

"This is a fight our family is staking everything on. Your presence alone will greatly raise morale."

"…"

I was still debating whether to accept when he continued.

"Fortunately, the Five Gates of Shanxi have agreed to help us. I want you to move with some of their people in the rear guard."

"The Five Gates of Shanxi?"

"An alliance of five small and mid-sized sects. They've always been on good terms with our family."

"…I see."

"Then will you take charge of the rear guard?"

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Rear Guard Defense
Jin Wikyung has proposed that you take charge of the rear guard.
If you accept this mission, the martial artists will praise your will and courage.
Type: Short-Term Quest
Grade: Second Rate
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Objective: Accept the proposal (Incomplete)
Reward: Fame +10
Failure: Fame −10

I answered without another thought.

"I will."

A message appeared announcing the Quest's completion and the increase in my Fame.

My Fame drops if I refuse?

The Quest Window had made me an offer I couldn't refuse. It was ridiculous, yet a strange sense of relief spread through me all the same.

Relief? Have I actually lost my mind?

As I berated myself for being a game addict, Jin Wikyung smiled broadly.

"I'm glad you're here."

He was smiling, but an invisible shadow hung over his face.

As if spending all day buried under stacks of paperwork wasn't enough, now there was a war. Leading a vast clan like the Jin Family of Taiyuan had to be a heavy burden even for him.

He said two days.

Two powers that divided an entire region between them were about to collide. The Jin Family of Taiyuan was short on martial artists, so even if we threw everything we had into the fight, we would still be at a disadvantage.

Can we win?

I forced the thought aside. What did I care whether they lived or died? The march was in two days, and it would take several more days for the battle to begin. No matter who won, I would be gone by the time a victor was decided.

Now it was time to hear what I needed to know.

"Um, there's something I wanted to ask."

"Go ahead."

"I'm still stuck at the Second Rate realm…"

After hearing me out, Jin Wikyung tilted his head.

"You're Second Rate?"

His tone said he couldn't understand what I was talking about. I had utterly crushed Lee Seogeun and even brought down Jopil. Jin Wikyung had assumed I was First Rate long ago, and so had Jopil.

"Yes. My realm just won't rise, so I was hoping you could give me some advice."

"Advice…"

Jin Wikyung thought for a moment before speaking.

"You're already First Rate."

"But I'm Second Rate."

"I'm telling you, you're First Rate. More than that, you're a Supreme First Rate martial artist standing at the wall of the Peak realm."

"No, I really am Second Rate…"

"Who told you that?"

Ugh, this is driving me crazy.

I wished I could show him the System Window. It plainly said Second Rate, but I was the only one who could see it, and the frustration was killing me.

I sighed.

“No one told me I was Second Rate.”

“Then?”

“It’s just… I’m Second Rate. I don’t really know how to explain it.”

“Do you believe you’re Second Rate?”

“Yes.”

“Then it’s simple.”

“Wh-what is?”

Is he finally going to reveal the secret to advancing realms?

I stared at Jin Wikyung, my eyes full of anticipation, but he said nothing. Instead, he dipped a finger into his cold tea and brought it to the table.

Scritch.

A single character appeared.

□

□? The character for “belief”?

Jin Wikyung took one look at my face and let out a short laugh.

“You look like you’ve just been slapped.”

“…You must be seeing things.”

More like I look like I want to slap you.

“What is this?”

“Exactly what it says. Believe in yourself.”

“What does that have to do with advancing realms?”

“Because martial arts begin with belief.”

Martial arts begin with belief? It sounded like airy nonsense. Yet the moment I heard those words, my heart began to pound.

They begin with belief…

For some reason, that one sentence kept circling through my mind, spinning around and around until I felt dizzy.

What had I believed in all this time?

The first word that came to mind—and the only one—was the System.

The thing that had helped me most in this game, the thing that had always told me nothing but absolute facts.

I had believed I was Second Rate because the System said I was Second Rate.

Because I believed in the System.

I had already overwhelmed Lee Seogeun, a First Rate master. I had taken down more than twenty wandering martial artists by myself and even defeated Jopil, a Peak master.

Everyone hailed me as a First Rate master and a hero, yet I had remained Second Rate.

Because I had believed in the System instead of myself.

But now I understood.

I'm already First Rate.

Already. Maybe I had been for a long time.

I was First Rate.

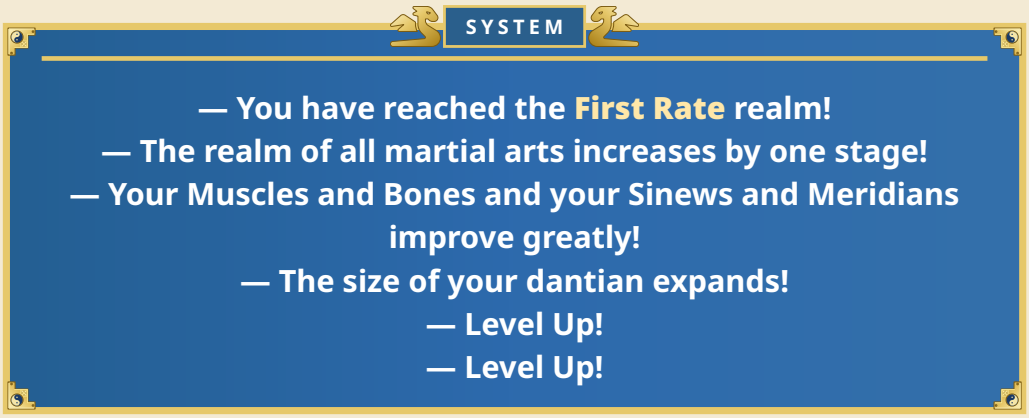
"You look like you've just been slapped."

This time, Jin Wikyung was right. I slumped against the back of my chair, stunned.

What a dumbass.

If I couldn't even believe in myself, I was Second Rate. No. I *had been* Second Rate.

Ding.



From Third Rate to Second Rate. Then from Second Rate to First Rate.

I felt power surge from deep within me, and Jin Wikyung burst out laughing.

"What happened?"

Wipeng showed up late and asked, looking bewildered.

It felt like a blocked nose had suddenly cleared. Reaching First Rate had brought a tremendous leap in every way—my senses, my martial arts, everything.

I left the main hall and started walking. The wind felt cool and refreshing.

"It's the Third Young Master."

"Has he fully recovered?"

Sure enough, people's gazes gathered on me. I changed course toward an even more crowded area.

Anyone watching would think I was desperate for attention.

But everything happens for a reason.

Ding.

SYSTEM

— Someone gazes at you with awe.
— Fame increases by 1.
— Someone is impressed after hearing rumors about you.
— Fame increases by 1.

As I walked, people gathered around me like clouds. Among them were plenty of NPCs wearing clothes I had never seen before.

Who are they?

I made eye contact with one of them. The young man looked to be in his early twenties. He flinched in surprise, then hurried over and gave me a fist-and-palm salute.

“Gwak of the Samdo Sect presents his respects.”

“Ah, yes.”

By now, the fist-and-palm salute came out on reflex and looked fairly convincing. But where was the Samdo Sect?

Oh. Could it be…?

“Are you with the Five Gates of Shanxi?”

Gwak Whatsisname nodded enthusiastically.

“That is correct. Our Samdo Sect has agreed to lend its strength to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I, Gwak, could not be more delighted to offer what little help I can.”

In a situation like this, he was a reinforcement worth his weight in gold. I took Gwak Whatsisname by the hand, hoping he would fight hard enough for both of us.

“Thank you for coming.”

“Please, think nothing of it. It is an honor simply to take part in the Young Master’s tale of martial valor.”

SYSTEM

— Someone is impressed after hearing rumors about you.
— Fame increases by 1.

A total stranger had come all this way to fight for us, and he was even making my Fame shoot up. I offered the endlessly generous Gwak Whatsisname my warmest thanks.

“God bless you.”

“Pardon?”

"It means I hope the Jade Emperor's[126] blessing will be with you."

"Ahh. Thank you. God bleshyoo."

"Ah. Yes."

I put on a fake smile and kept walking. Maybe because everyone who needed to know about me already did, the Jin Family of Taiyuan's people no longer raised my Fame.

Still, I've built up quite a bit.

I opened the Status Window and saw that I was about fifty points short of the target. If I grinded hard for two more days, maybe I could log out.

"Um, Young Hero Jin."

I turned around. It was the fellow from the Samdo Sect. He looked ready to follow me to the ends of the earth.

"If you aren't busy, perhaps we could have some tea together…"

"I'm sorry. I have somewhere to be."

It sounded like a lie, but it was the truth. My destination had been decided from the start.

I pointed to a building as disappointment crossed his face. A faded signboard hung above it, and the heavy smell of medicinal decoctions wafted from within.

Medicine King Hall.

Beneath the signboard hung a small wooden plaque.

Authorized Personnel Only.

The people surrounding me let out pitying sighs.

[126]The Jade Emperor is a deity in Daoist tradition.

Chapter 35

A hospital room in Medicine King Hall.

Hyuk Mujin, wound tight in bandages from head to toe, let out a groan.

“I’m dying.”

Han Yeop, lying beside him in much the same state, replied,

“It’s a miracle we didn’t die.”

“Right?”

“That’s right.”

A brief silence followed. Both of them were remembering that day.

Jopil’s palm strike. An attack they couldn’t have blocked even if they had known it was coming. Whenever Hyuk Mujin closed his eyes, he saw that bastard’s red-hot palm. It might haunt his nightmares for the rest of his life.

“That monster. How is something like that even possible?”

“He’s a Peak master.”

Unlike the dejected Hyuk Mujin, Han Yeop sounded calm.

“Hey, punk. Doesn’t any of that bother you?”

“What?”

“That…”

Hyuk Mujin found himself at a loss for words. Right. Maybe Han Yeop really was fine.

“No, that’s not what I meant…”

“I know.”

“Huh?”

“I know what you’re thinking, Deputy Squad Leader. I know what you want to say.”

“…”

“When I first came to, all kinds of things went through my mind. The relief of being alive. The helplessness I felt that day. The despair over my own martial arts.”

Hyuk Mujin fell silent. Han Yeop had it exactly right. Jopil’s Flame Divine Palm had broken his bones and torn his heart meridian, but his real wound lay elsewhere.

One question had been circling through his mind ever since that day.

Can I ever reach that realm?

Even “overwhelming” didn’t begin to describe it. All his hard work, all the pride he had taken in his martial arts, had been ripped up by the roots.

“You’ve shaken all that off?”

Han Yeop shook his head.

“Then?”

"I accepted that I'm weak. It wasn't even that hard. I've always known it. But…"

"…"

"I'll get stronger. As strong as Jopil. No—much stronger."

Han Yeop continued, his voice firm.

"Once I started thinking that way, I felt happy. If I become a Peak master, I can be that strong too. That sort of thing."

"A Peak master…"

The Peak realm was open to only a rare few. Coming from Han Yeop, who was barely second- or third-rate, the declaration was almost laughable.

But Hyuk Mujin didn't sneer.

You've changed too.

So much had changed. Their circumstances. The people around him.

Even that timid second-rate martial artist had been swept up in the current before anyone noticed. Hyuk Mujin felt his heart swell, and the next words burst out before he could stop them.

"I'll get even stronger."

Han Yeop's eyes widened, then he broke into a grin.

"You will. First, though, we have to catch up to one person."

They both thought of the same man.

Jin Taekyung.

He was already running far ahead of them. What was he doing now?

Behind the two men, lost in thought, the door that had been left slightly ajar quietly slid shut.

I closed the door, turned away, and shuddered from head to toe.

"Ugh, shit."

These idiots were shooting a teenage coming-of-age drama in a hospital room. I'd stood there listening to see what they were talking about, and what a sight it had been. Seriously.

If I'd gone in, I might've ended up swearing brotherhood with them.

Still, I have to admit it was kind of admirable.

We'd been through life and death together, after all. Besides, those two had risked their lives to help me. I'd be lying if I said I didn't feel even a shred of affection for them.

Could this be the last time I see them?

In two days, I would set out in command of the main force's rear guard, while those two and the rest of the injured reconnaissance squad stayed behind with the family. And probably…

By then, I'll have logged out.

I was close to meeting the final condition of the Logout Quest: 500 Fame. Today's visit to Medicine King Hall was a farewell of sorts.

You could call it the nostalgia filter of a sergeant in his last stretch before discharge.

Well, there's no need to tell them. Seeing their faces is enough.

I'd already looked in on the other reconnaissance squad members. Now that I'd seen Han Yeop and Hyuk Mujin too, there was only one more place to visit…

Huh?

"Oh!"

A rag doll in one hand. Snacks in the other.

A little girl with her hair tied in a cute ribbon stared at me with round eyes and shouted,

"It's the mind-reading mister!"[127]

"…"

Couldn't you call me Big Brother? I gave Soyul a sad little wave.

"Young Master Jin."

"Benefactor!"

The moment I entered the room, they both reacted. I stopped the still-pale Gong Yacheong from rising, then hauled Socheon back to his feet after he dropped into a full bow.

"Stay lying down. And you, get up, punk. Am I old enough to have you bowing to me?"

"You have shown me a kindness a hundred bows could never repay."

Tears were already welling in both their eyes. Soyul, who didn't understand what was happening, hugged her rag doll tight and scampered over to cling to her brother.

"Big brother, did you put on the Benefactor's kindness? Show me too. Is it pretty?"

Uh. That's clothes, isn't it?

Leaving the chattering Soyul behind, I turned to Gong Yacheong.

"How are you feeling?"

[127] *Gwansimbeop*, the "mind-reading" Soyul refers to, is associated in Korean popular culture with Gung Ye, a ruler portrayed in the television drama *Taejo Wang Geon*.

"Couldn't be better. Though I'll need to recuperate for a while."

A faint smile spread across Gong Yacheong's lips.

"It is all thanks to you, Young Master."

"I didn't do it for praise. I even left you behind once."

"That was my choice. And you came back."

I remembered that night Jopil had been chasing us. Gong Yacheong had been badly poisoned and had wanted to stay behind. Just as he had, I'd had to make a choice.

After a long struggle with myself, I had decided to go back for him.

And I regretted it like crazy.

It had been insane. Gambling my life for a mere NPC in a game. But now I thought I understood why I had made that choice.

What had I seen in those young siblings who had lost their parents? Who had Gong Yacheong and the reconnaissance squad reminded me of...?

"Young Master Jin?"

Gong Yacheong's voice pulled me back.

"It's nothing. I just—just had something on my mind."

"Ah, I heard the news as well. Is that what this is about?"

"What news?"

"They say there will soon be a major battle."

Wasn't that military intelligence?

If Gong Yacheong, who never left his hospital room, knew about it, then everyone in the Jin Family of Taiyuan with eyes and ears must know.

If there was even one spy among us, we might as well have installed a loudspeaker aimed at North Korea.[128]

Is this war really going to be all right like this?

I shook off the thought. What did it matter to me? Soon enough, none of this would have anything to do with me anyway.

The System alerts ringing even now were proof.

Ding.

SYSTEM

— Rumors about you continue to spread.
— Fame increases by 1.

[128] South Korea has used loudspeakers along its border to broadcast messages into North Korea. Taekyung is joking that news of the battle is spreading just as openly.

As the saying went, words without feet could travel a thousand li.[129] Ever since I'd taken Jopil down, my name seemed to have started spreading in earnest.

I opened the Quest Window for a quick look. I had only about fifty Fame left to go.

Logout was practically a foregone conclusion.

"It will be a battle with our family's fate at stake."

Of course, neither of them had any way of knowing my situation. I listened quietly to Gong Yacheong and Socheon for a while, then rose from my seat.

"I should get going."

"Benefactor."

Socheon looked disappointed, but Gong Yacheong stopped him.

"Let him go."

"But…"

"That is enough."

Socheon lowered his head glumly. Soyul, who had been playing alone with her doll, looked up at me with huge eyes.

"You're leaving already, mister?"

"I said Big Brother."

"Okay. Mister."

I gave her chubby cheek a light pinch and was about to turn away when Gong Yacheong called out to me.

"Young Master Jin. Even if you must leave, should you not take what you left behind?"

"What I left behind?"

I thought about it for a moment, but there was no way I'd forgotten anything. Thanks to the cheat feature known as Inventory, I always traveled light.

"I didn't leave anyth—what is this?"

Gong Yacheong was holding a long bundle.

"You were in no state to collect it at the time. Now that its owner has come, it is only right that I return it."

What is it?

Still bewildered, I took the bundle. It was fairly heavy. Just as I was about to check what was inside, Gong Yacheong spoke.

"Unwrap it in your quarters. Do not let anyone else see."

Did he put a golden calf in here?

[129] A thousand Korean *ri* is about 393 km (244 mi). The distance is figurative here.

I unwrapped the bundle the moment I reached my quarters. Then I understood what Gong Yacheong's last words had meant.

These really are the sort of things people would covet if they saw them.

An old booklet. A small box. And a familiar sword.

To someone in Murim, these were beyond comparison to any golden calf. And I had the ability to judge that value more accurately than anyone.

Check Item.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Flame Divine Palm
Type: Martial Arts Manual
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Holder of Scorching Yang Qi
Description: One of the Fire Gate Clan's secret techniques. A martial art based on powerful fire qi.
Effect: Acquired Flame Divine Palm
Item Window
Blazing Flame Divine Pill
Type: Spiritual Elixir
Grade: Peak
Restriction: None
Description: A spiritual elixir made according to the Fire Gate Clan's secret formula.
Effect: Grants thirty years of internal energy when consumed. However, if the user cannot control the powerful fire qi contained within the elixir, they may meet a horrific end.
Item Window
Unnamed Sword
Type: Sword
Grade: None
Restriction: None
Description: Made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, this sword is exceptionally sharp and durable. After drinking a great deal of blood over many years, it transformed on its own. Special conditions are required to draw out the sword's power.
Effect: Unknown

"This is insane."

It really was insane. A Supreme Peak martial arts manual. A spiritual elixir that granted thirty years of internal energy. And a sword I didn't fully understand, but that looked ridiculously good.

They said a tiger left its pelt behind when it died, but Jopil had left three treasures behind.

Shit. It always gives me the good stuff after everything's over.

Damn shitty game. If it was going to give me something, it should've done it sooner. Waiting until everything was finished to play catch-up just made my blood pressure spike.

Still, these items are seriously good.

Reading the descriptions, I couldn't help feeling tempted. What if I took the elixir and learned Flame Divine Palm? If fire started shooting from my hands like Jopil's…

That would be fucking cool.

But the thought lasted only a moment. They said a soldier nearing the end of his service had to watch out even for falling leaves. I had no intention of swallowing the elixir wrong and staging my own self-immolation ceremony.

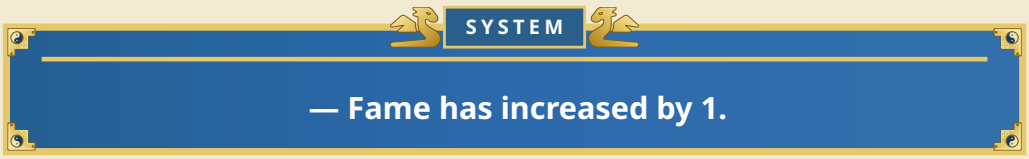
Remember. Safety first. Safety first.

Talking about safety after everything I'd done was pretty funny, but I wasn't stupid enough to gulp it down without thinking.

It's almost over.

One wrong step and I was finished. I stuffed all the items into my Inventory. Somewhere in the dead of night, someone must have been talking about me over drinks, because a System alert rang out.

Ding.



At that hour, the Head Elder was strolling through the garden.

This was the agreed-upon date and place. The man waiting in the darkness was never late.

"The moon is very bright tonight."

"So it is."

As he had said, the full moon shone exceptionally brightly.

"When I was young, I loved the moon… but the older I got, the more I found myself thinking."

"Thinking what?"

"That I wished the moon didn't exist. Something like that."

"A world without charm."

"What's wrong with a little less charm? I make my living at night, so I'd be delighted if the moon disappeared."

Night life, huh.

The man prattled on in the flippant, cheerful tone of a kept man, but the Head Elder knew the truth. He possessed formidable martial arts and was a superb assassin.

The wind seemed to carry the smell of blood.

"Ah, right. How is the work progressing?"

"Smoothly. Even the troop deployments are complete."

"Do not overdo it. If the clever Lesser Family Head catches the scent, everything will fall apart."

"Do not worry. I did not even need to make a move."

"Heaven is helping us."

"And your side?"

"You are asking the obvious."

The mild reproach in his voice silenced the Head Elder.

As if it could be otherwise.

They were like sea fog. Their identities lay hidden within the mist, and no matter how one reached out and stirred it, there was nothing solid to grasp. All that remained was a damp palm and an unpleasant feeling.

But they have power.

The power to make him Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the sole hegemon of Shanxi Province.

It was an ambition he had harbored for half his life. The Head Elder was prepared to do anything.

"All preparations are complete."

"Mine as well."

On the day the two great sects that divided Shanxi between them clashed…

Everything would end, and everything would begin anew.

Chapter 36

SYSTEM

Quest
Logout
You must now make your way through this harsh Murim.
Become even stronger, and become famous.
For the day that will one day come…
Grade: Main Quest
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Objective: Reach the **First Rate** realm (Complete)
Reach Lv. 30 (Complete)
Reach Fame 500 (475/500)
Reward: Logout

I closed the Quest Window. It was the middle of winter, but I felt a cold sweat coming on.

If this keeps up, I'm completely screwed.

My Fame had been creeping upward little by little, only to stop dead half a day ago. I'd bolted out of my quarters and gone around shaking hands like a presidential candidate until my hands nearly fell off, but the notification I was waiting for never came.

No, I did get a notification.

Beep!

SYSTEM

— There is no one in the Jin Family of Taiyuan who does not know of your Fame.

It was the System's way of telling me I'd already milked this place for all the Fame it was worth, so I should knock it off. Even the System seemed to find me pitiful.

And so an entire day slipped helplessly away. Today was the long-awaited departure ceremony.

"Fuck…"

As I muttered the curse under my breath, Jin Wikyung was climbing onto the platform.

Hundreds of pairs of eyes followed him. The martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and those from the small and mid-sized sects that had recently joined us stood in formation across the Grand Training Ground, more than five hundred strong.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

A tremendous rumble began to spread. Some stamped their feet; others struck their weapons. When five hundred martial artists with internal energy moved as one, the earth shook and a deafening roar filled heaven and earth.

What the…?

I had never seen anything like it. No longer individuals, they had become a single army, waiting for one man's command.

At last, Jin Wikyung spoke.

"I will not deny it. The enemy surpasses us both in troop numbers and in the number of Peak masters."

Silence descended in an instant. But Jin Wikyung wasn't foolish enough to crush morale with his opening words. The force of his presence was proof of that.

"However."

His usual good-natured smile was nowhere to be seen. The Jin Wikyung standing before us was both a Peak martial artist and the head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

"They are nothing but jackals with numbers on their side. That man's rabble—wandering martial artists blinded by gold, and a pack of mounted bandits who have plundered the common people!"

The air crackled beneath his fiery shout. For that moment, even I felt my blood begin to boil.

"They have neither cause nor justice."

Cause. Justice.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had lost the two most important things in any war.

That was why the small and mid-sized sects of Shanxi Province, which had only watched from the sidelines while the two great powers fought, had sent reinforcements.

"This war will be over within three days."

Fifteen hundred martial artists would clash at the same hour on the same day.

It would be a hellish battle of killing and being killed.

"No one here can be certain whether they will live or die. However…"

Jin Wikyung's flashing gaze swept across them all.

"We will prevail."

The next moment, a roar erupted loud enough to leave my ears ringing. With the crowd's fervor at its peak, Jin Wikyung towered over them like a giant.

"Survival of the fittest! Put your lives on the line, fight, and survive!"

The cheering continued for a long time afterward.

Our five hundred troops were divided into the vanguard, center, and rear guard. Most of our core fighting strength had been assigned to the vanguard and center, so the rear guard under my command consisted of only a few dozen martial artists.

Among them were several familiar faces.

“Captain!”

They were members of the reconnaissance squad. Both pleased and puzzled, I asked, “Why are you guys here? Weren’t you at Medicine King Hall?”

“This battle will decide the fate of our family. We can’t sit it out just because we’re a little injured.”

When I’d secretly visited them last time, some of them had still had cracked bones in their arms and legs. Murim people really were tough as hell.

“We asked to be placed under your command, and the higher-ups readily approved it. We’ve been able to walk around with our chests puffed out ever since that day. Haha.”

“Well, look at you.”

A quiet laugh escaped me.

I’d spent several days with them during the reconnaissance mission, but I still didn’t know some of their names. Even so, I felt close to them. We had been through life and death together.

They say three raids are enough to make sworn brothers.

I smiled at the eight members of the reconnaissance squad. Then something occurred to me.

No, wait.

Eight? Had I counted wrong?

I started counting again from the end, one person at a time. There had originally been nine, not including me. Hyuk Mujin and Han Yeop had both been severely injured, so naturally neither of them should have been here. That meant there should have been seven, but…

“…What are you doing here?”

Even as I stared at him, I couldn’t be sure it was really the same guy. His face was puffed up like a steamed bun, and the skin showing beyond his clothes was red and blotchy.

“Can’t you tell by looking?”

Right. There was only one bastard on the reconnaissance squad rude enough to answer like that.

“Hyuk Mujin?”

“Yes. Why? What?”

“Are you really Hyuk Mujin?”

"You can't even recognize my face anymore?"

Looking like that, even your parents wouldn't recognize you…

More importantly, why the hell was he here?

"Did you volunteer too?"

"I did."

Then he added, "They wouldn't take me, though."

"Huh?"

"I told the physician, and he got angry and asked if I was out of my mind and trying to get myself killed. So I snuck out."

I spoke seriously.

"Are you out of your mind and trying to get yourself killed?"

"I want to live."

Hyuk Mujin answered with a sour expression.

"Then why did you come?"

"I know my own condition. I can fight well enough."

"Your face looks ready to burst."

"The swelling is going down. My internal injuries are completely healed, so there's no problem."

"What about your external injuries?"

"They'll heal on the way."

"…"

"A few bones are cracked, but I can handle—urk!"

Hyuk Mujin suddenly doubled over. Startled, I shouted, "Hey! What's wrong?"

"Sometimes my chest hurts when I breathe… Ah, it's fine now."

"…"

Was this guy completely insane?

As I stood there speechless, Hyuk Mujin continued.

"Ah, Han Yeop couldn't come. His internal injuries still haven't healed, so he would've only been a burden. Captain? Captain, you are listening to me, right?"

There was only one thought in my head.

Logout. I need to log out, now.

Night came early in winter. The sun set, and after we had walked for who knew how long, we finally entered a broad basin and received the order to make camp.

"Ugh, every bone in my body hurts."

Hyuk Mujin groaned. He clearly hadn't fully recovered, and the march seemed to be taking its toll.

"It's not too late. Want to turn back?"

"Are you saying that again?"

"I'm saying it because you look like you're struggling."

"You're imagining things. Does Hyuk Mujin the man look like someone who'd be exhausted after walking for a mere half day?"

I nodded without the slightest hesitation.

"Yep."

"Absolutely not!"

"Hmm. You're really not tired? You're fine?"

"Yes."

"Then go help the others set up camp."

At that moment, Hyuk Mujin the man's eyes widened, and he sank to the ground.

"Ugh, the internal injuries Jopil gave me…"

"…"

You said your internal injuries were completely healed, you bastard.

I was wondering whether I should give him a good smack when a voice interrupted us.

"Is he injured?"

A huge shadow stretched beneath the moonlight. Hyuk Mujin cautiously raised his head to see who it was, and his eyes flew open.

"Gasp! Lesser Family Head!"

If Jin Wikyung was a division commander, Hyuk Mujin was a private.

The next moment, Hyuk Mujin sprang up like lightning and stood at attention. Jin Wikyung burst out laughing.

"You still don't look fully recovered. Go ahead and lie down. Ah, but your internal injuries certainly seem to have healed. I'll vouch for that."

"Ah, I… That isn't…"

Jin Wikyung lightly patted the flustered Hyuk Mujin on the shoulder, then turned to me.

"Shall we walk for a bit?"

I followed Jin Wikyung to a secluded corner. He spoke first.

"How are you feeling?"

"Good."

I'd gotten full use out of the level-up. My body had recovered at a terrifying speed, and distributing my points had made it even stronger.

The problem lay elsewhere.

My Fame isn't going up.

No, it was going up. By a rat dropping's worth. Little by little. Very, very little.

At this rate, there was no guarantee I'd be able to log out before the fighting started.

At least, not if things stayed like this.

Jin Wikyung's arrival was perfect timing. I brought up the idea I'd been mulling over.

"I want a mission."

His eyes widened at my blunt request.

"Hm? A mission?"

"Now that I've recovered, I want to distinguish myself for our family."

I was proud of myself. To think I could deliver a line like that—a lie like that—with a straight face.

"I-is that truly what you think?"

"Yes."

The corners of Jin Wikyung's eyes trembled. He seemed overcome with emotion.

This is actually making me feel a little guilty.

The only reason I was putting on this ridiculous act was to gain Fame. If I went out on a reconnaissance mission and accomplished something, the Fame would come rolling in.

Even better if I ran into a reconnaissance unit from the Mount Heng Sword Sect. They would provide excellent EXP and enough Fame to fill the rest of the bar.

Once the real battle starts, I'm screwed.

I had to log out before then, and fast. I spoke with firm resolve.

"Just leave it to me."

"What made you think of doing something so admirable? Thank you, my youngest."

Jin Wikyung wiped the damp corners of his eyes with his sleeve and continued.

"But no."

"Then give me a reconnaissance mission—what?"

"I appreciate the thought. Continue guarding the rear."

What the hell is he talking about?

I barely suppressed the urge to grab him by the collar and shake him.

"I-I really want to distinguish myself."

"You've already done more than enough."

"No, that's not what I mean."

"The merits you've earned so far have already been a tremendous help to our family. So don't trouble yourself over it."

"I'd like you to give me at least one reconnaissance mission. There might be enemies lying in ambush ahead…"

Jin Wikyung chuckled.

“This battle will decide our family’s fate. Do you think I wouldn’t have accounted for something like that?”

“Couldn’t there be a one-in-ten-thousand chance that something was overlooked?”

“That is quite literally a one-in-ten-thousand chance.”

Damn it.

Nothing was going my way. What if I really failed to reach the required Fame? Then I would have to fight in a massive battle involving fifteen hundred people.

I’m fucked.

Something large and warm settled on my dejected shoulder. Jin Wikyung’s hand.

“Youngest.”

His voice was heavy and lonely. At the sudden shift in mood, I fell silent and listened.

“Your mission is more important than anyone else’s.”

“What is my mission?”

After a long pause, he forced out a single word.

“Survive.”

“What?”

“Survive, no matter what. If our family loses, run without looking back.”

“…”

“If the roots survive, the tree will grow again. Second Brother and you could become better roots than I ever could.”

I was speechless. For a long time, all I could do was stare at his face.

Survive. Become roots.

His voice and gaze carried a gravity that struck me more deeply than ever before.

“That is your mission.”

The palm resting on my shoulder slid slowly down. I stared after Jin Wikyung’s departing back, unable to look away.

Chapter 37

The march went smoothly. The heavy snow that had fallen during our last reconnaissance mission had melted long ago, and command set a pace that conserved as much of the troops' strength as possible.

"At this rate, we'll reach Jeongyang by tomorrow at the latest."

I blinked at the oddly familiar man's words.

"Who are you?"

Judging by his clothes, he wasn't from the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Aside from the reconnaissance squad, most of the rear guard consisted of martial artists from the newly allied small and mid-sized sects, so that made sense.

"I'm Gwak Jun of the Samdo Sect. We met once before… We even shook hands."

Gwak Jun of the Samdo Sect? It felt like I should remember him.

It wasn't as if I'd shaken only one or two hands trying to raise my Fame.

He was probably one of them.

"Sorry. My memory isn't very good."

"I wasn't expecting you to remember, honestly. Haha."

Gwak Jun gave me a friendly smile and continued.

"To be honest, I was disappointed at first when I found out we'd been assigned to the rear guard."

"Why?"

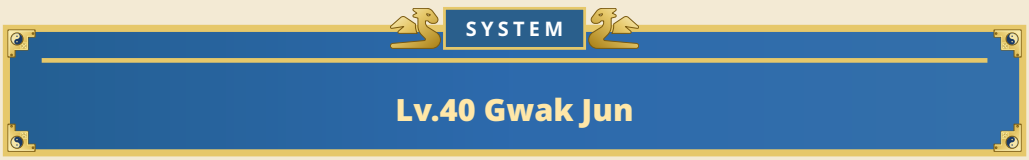
"Because there'd be fewer chances to distinguish ourselves. Isn't this the perfect opportunity for an unknown grunt like me to make a name for himself?"

"Ah. Right."

There were two possibilities in cases like this. Either he'd fought in so many battles that he'd developed nerves of steel, or he simply had no fear.

I raised my **Qi Sense**.

Ding.



Oh. He's pretty good.

At Level 40, he was at least First Rate. He couldn't exactly go around bragging that he was a master, but he was good enough to resent being stuck in the rear.

"Half of the enemy troops were recruited in a hurry. They've dragged in every kind of deadweight, and they must have force-marched to join the main force.

They won't stand a chance against the elites of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Samdo Sect."

His argument sounded plausible enough.

If you leave out the part about the Samdo Sect being elite.

I nodded halfheartedly.

"I see."

"And our Peak masters are superior to theirs. There's the Lesser Family Head and Great Hero Wipeng, of course, but the fame of the Blade of Flowers has spread throughout the Central Plains, hasn't it?"

The Blade of Flowers. It was the first time I'd heard the title, but I could guess who he meant.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had three Peak masters. Excluding Jin Wikyung and Wipeng, only one person remained.

The Head Elder.

Was that old man really that strong?

Everything Gwak Jun said next was praise. Title after title, name after name of masters the Head Elder had cut down in his youth decades ago came spilling out.

"He was a hero born of the Great Faction War."

A war hero from the past. Listening to Gwak Jun, he sounded like the noblest of chivalrous heroes—a man who loved justice and couldn't stand to see injustice go unpunished…

Then why do I feel uneasy every time I see him?

Maybe it was because of my first impression, but I didn't like the Head Elder.

That peculiar air of his. The strange gaze that seemed to bore straight through people. The fact that he had formed a political faction in opposition to Jin Wikyung.

Since then, however, the Head Elder had thrown his full support behind Jin Wikyung, allowing the Jin Family of Taiyuan to present a united front both inside and out.

Well, when an outside enemy invades, even family feuds have to stop.

The Head Elder was currently leading the vanguard alongside Jin Wikyung. If he truly was as skilled as the rumors claimed, tomorrow's battle would be that much easier.

"Just thinking of Great Hero Blade of Flowers sweeping the battlefield tomorrow already has my heart racing."

Gwak Jun shuddered like a man finally taking a piss after holding it for three days.

Does this bastard not know what tension is?

And where was he getting all this confidence that we were going to win?

"You sound certain we'll win."

"If we lose, we'll be in big trouble."

"Excuse me?"

Not big trouble. We'd be finished.

Judging by everything the Mount Heng Sword Sect had done so far, they would raze not only the Jin Family of Taiyuan but every small and mid-sized sect allied with us.

"What do you mean by—"

"I'm joking."

This bastard's a lunatic too.

As I stared at him in disbelief, Gwak Jun flashed me a grin.

"We'll win. We will."

The words rang with absolute conviction.

After Gwak Jun walked away, Hyuk Mujin came over and asked,

"Who was that?"

"Level 40."

"What?"

"Just some guy overflowing with confidence."

I didn't like him for several reasons.

Well, it wasn't as though I'd ever have to talk to him again.

Time passed quickly. On the second night of the march, we reached Honju, and Jin Wikyung gathered the command staff for a meeting. He held a small slip of paper in one hand.

"A letter from the Lower District Sect. The enemy reinforcements crossed Mount Otae two days ago."

"Then…"

"They're likely to join the main force around now, or sometime tomorrow."

What?

I didn't understand. If we had attacked the main force before the reinforcements joined them, the battle would have been much easier.

He must have something in mind.

Sure enough, Jin Wikyung continued.

"The enemy reinforcements are exhausted, and their food supplies are nearly gone. If we seize the advantageous ground at Jeongyang first tomorrow, the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect will face a choice. Retreat or clash with us."

The next moment, Jin Wikyung looked at me.

"What choice do you think he'll make?"

The sudden question caught me off guard, but the answer was obvious. If he were the kind of man to retreat at this point, he would have done so long ago.

“I think he’ll clash with us.”

They had nearly twice our numbers, and they weren’t behind us in Peak masters either. From the enemy’s perspective, the best option was to end the battle quickly and decisively.

“Exactly.”

Jin Wikyung smiled in satisfaction and traced a finger across the topographic map spread over the table.

“There are four routes the enemy can take into Jeongyang. But with their food situation as it is, they’ll choose the fastest one.”

His finger stopped on a place labeled Eight Spring Gorge. The Head Elder, who had been sitting quietly until then, spoke for the first time.

“Eight Spring Gorge. Jar-shaped, with a narrow, steep entrance. The mounted bandits will have to abandon their prized horses.”

“They’ll have to abandon their lives as well.”

“The enemy will fight with their lives on the line. This alone will not be enough.”

“I’ve hidden some hundred horn bows on the cliffs above the gorge.”

“Hoh.”

A stir ran through the tent. I stared at Jin Wikyung with my mouth open.

When the hell did he hide those there?

“Right after our victory at Honju. Thanks to a resourceful helper.”

Jin Wikyung looked straight at me as he spoke.

The Lower District Sect. Wolhwa.

She had been helping us constantly from places we couldn’t see. Of course, Jin Wikyung was impressive too, for putting together a plan this big.

That’s fucking cool.

A body like a human meat grinder and a brilliant mind to go with it. Suddenly I wanted to call him hyung.[130]

“Oh!”

“Lesser Family Head…!”

The tent grew hot beneath the burning gazes of all those rough-looking men.

Jin Wikyung swept his solemn gaze over everyone assembled.

“Let’s settle this.”

No one objected. The Head Elder was the first to rise and give Jin Wikyung a fist-in-palm salute.[131]

“By your command.”

---

[130] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

[131] A fist-in-palm salute is a traditional martial greeting used to show respect.

That brought the meeting to an end. As I left the tent, a familiar voice pierced my ear.

“Do not forget what I told you yesterday.”

I stiffened for a moment, then gave a small nod.

At dawn, three hundred martial artists from the Jin Family of Taiyuan and one hundred fifty reinforcements from the small and mid-sized sects—four hundred fifty in all—departed for the gorge.

Even though this was goodbye, I never got to say it properly.

I climbed a hill and stared for a long time at the winding line of torches.

The next morning, Hyuk Mujin flinched when he saw me and stepped back.

“You startled me. What happened?”

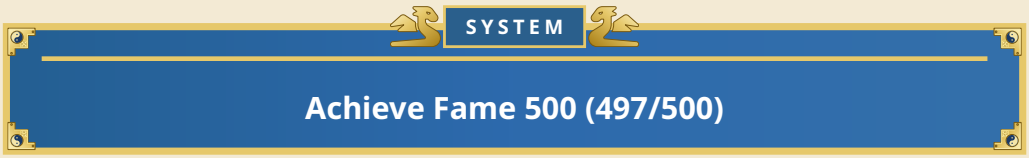
“What?”

“What do you mean, what? You look like a walking corpse. Didn’t you sleep?”

“Nah. I slept a little.”

That was a lie. I hadn’t slept a wink. I had spent the entire night perched on a rock, staring at the System Window.

Eagerly awaiting the moment that had finally drawn near.



I never knew the number one could feel so precious.

In a voice that seemed to have aged overnight, I muttered,

“I’m going, I’m going, now I’m going home…”

“Now you’re even talking to yourself. Have you lost your mind?”

Hyuk Mujin clicked his tongue, then his eyes widened.

“What are those? I’ve never seen them before.”

“These?”

I pointed in turn at the old book and the small box resting on the rock.

“One’s a martial arts manual. The other’s an elixir.”

“Gasp. Really?”

I listlessly explained to the guy whose eyes were halfway out of their sockets.

“The manual contains a Supreme Peak martial art, and if you absorb the elixir properly, it’ll give you half a jiazi.[132]”

[132] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; half a jiazi is thirty years.

“What?”

“But if you take the elixir wrong, apparently you’ll burn to death. Want it?”

“Ah. Sure…”

Judging by his unimpressed face and the way his lips were sticking out a mile, he didn’t believe a damn word I was saying.

Well, if someone suddenly came at me with a Supreme Peak martial art and a thirty-year Fireball elixir, I’d assume it was a joke too.

“You really won’t eat it? It’s good stuff.”

“Oh, I’m fine. Learn plenty of that Supreme Peak martial art, and make sure you chew your elixir thoroughly.”

“I don’t need this kind of thing anymore.”

“Of course not. You’re the Hidden Dragon.”

Normally, I would have smacked him in the back of the head. Right now, I didn’t feel much of anything.

Is this how a short-timer sergeant feels?[133]

At the same time, I felt strangely wistful. Maybe it was an aftereffect of everything I’d been through. I had only been here for a little over a month, yet it felt as though a whole year had passed.

I began tracing back through my memories.

I first opened my eyes at Honghwaru.

That was where I met Wolhwa for the first time and realized I was trapped in this game. Even now, thinking about that moment gave me goose bumps.

I really thought I was going to lose my mind.

It had taken me three days just to decide to go to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. And the guy I met there was this one—Hyuk Mujin.

Smack!

“Argh! Why did you hit me?”

“Hmm. Just thinking about the old days.”

“What old days?”

“Nope. Not telling. Now hurry back.”

“What are you, some back-alley thug? Just because your martial arts are a bit stronger, you think you can bully people like this?”

As Hyuk Mujin threw a fit, everyone turned to look at us. Even the reconnaissance-squad members who had been watching from the sidelines joined in.

“What are you two talking about?”

“Dunno. The deputy captain must have done something wrong.”

“Hey, I didn’t do anything!”

[133] A conscript sergeant in the last stretch of mandatory service, coasting toward discharge.

“This is Murim. Being weak is a crime.”

“But should we really be acting like this?”

At someone’s words, silence fell for a moment.

“True. Waiting here is our mission, but…”

The tension and fear they had been suppressing with forced smiles rose to the surface. Even I, who would soon be returning to the real world, felt uneasy whenever Jin Wikyung’s face came to mind. How much worse must it be for these guys?

There was only one thing I could say.

“I trust my hyung.[134]”

Hyung.[135]

This time, I put my heart into the word.

Jin Wikyung had been my greatest source of strength in this place. Maybe I simply wanted to shake off that unease, even if only by saying it aloud.

The tension eased from everyone’s faces.

“We feel the same.”

Hyuk Mujin slipped in as well.

“I trust the Captain more.”

“Wow. Deputy Captain, you’re awfully quick to switch sides.”

“You little bastards. Is there anyone here who doesn’t owe the Captain their life?”

“Well, when you put it that way, what can we say?”

“I trust the Captain too. Honestly, I knew all along, even when you were pretending to be a thug. I thought, *Ah, that man is the Hidden Dragon.* I could tell right away.”

It felt strange.

Even dried squid gives up water if you squeeze it hard enough. Who knew I’d feel something like this toward NPCs in a game?

Well, honestly… it doesn’t feel bad.

Suddenly, I found myself wondering about Jin Wikyung, somewhere beyond those mountains. Had the battle started? If so, which side was winning?

And I wasn’t the only one thinking about it.

“By now, the battle must have started.”

It was Gwak Jun of the Samdo Sect. Unlike before, he was dressed in black martial robes.

Was that what he was wearing before?

When he noticed me looking, Gwak Jun shrugged.

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[134] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

[135] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

“I like this sort of thing. It’s easy to move in, and even if a little blood splatters on it, no one can tell. You agree, don’t you?”

The last question wasn’t directed at us. It was meant for the Samdo Sect martial artists under his command. Every last one of them had changed into black, and they nodded without a word.

“Apparently they do.”

Gwak Jun smiled in satisfaction, then turned to me.

“Well, shall we set out too?”

What the fuck is this bastard talking about right now?

Chapter 38

The first thing I felt was confusion.

“Set out?”

Gwak Jun answered.

“Yes. Our side needs to get moving too, or we won’t make it in time.”

At those cryptic words, Hyuk Mujin stepped forward.

“You there, from the Samdo Sect. You seem to have the wrong idea. Our mission is to wait here in the rear with the Young Master.”

“Oh, is that so?”

Gwak Jun’s eyes went round. At his reaction, the reconnaissance-squad members nodded with looks that said, *That figures.*

“Looks like I had it wrong.”

“It happens. Sure it does.”

But I thought otherwise.

What do you mean, it happens?

There were twenty Samdo Sect martial artists left in the rear. Gwak Jun was their leader.

Would a guy like that mix up his orders?

He was unpleasant, no question, but he didn’t look that stupid.

Dread crept over me.

“That’s a problem. The mission I received is a little different.”

“How is it different?”

As I spoke, I pressed down firmly on Hyuk Mujin’s foot. He horsed around dozens of times a day, but he wasn’t an idiot. His eyes widened as he caught my signal.

“Captain, please move your foot. It hurts.”

“…”

For fuck’s sake.

Gwak Jun’s mouth curled as he watched me stare in disbelief.

“You catch on fast. Or are your subordinates just idiots? Well, anyway. I’ll tell you exactly what that person said.”

The smile vanished from Gwak Jun’s face. With the cold, emotionless gaze of a killer, he continued.

“Eliminate everyone and join the main force.”

Clang-clang-clang!

The instant the words left his mouth, dozens of sword flashes shot into the air. Killing intent and tension hung between the twenty martial artists Gwak Jun led and the reconnaissance-squad members, who drew their swords half a beat later.

“Have you bastards lost your minds…?”

Hyuk Mujin ground his teeth and glared at them.

“You dare betray our family? Are you that desperate to die?”

“Betray? Die? You’re badly mistaken.”

A sneer tugged at Gwak Jun’s mouth.

“We never betrayed anyone, and we aren’t going to die. Least of all to trash like you.”

“You son of a—!”

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes went wild as he threw himself at Gwak Jun.

Or tried to.

“Stay put.”

“Captain?”

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes flew wide.

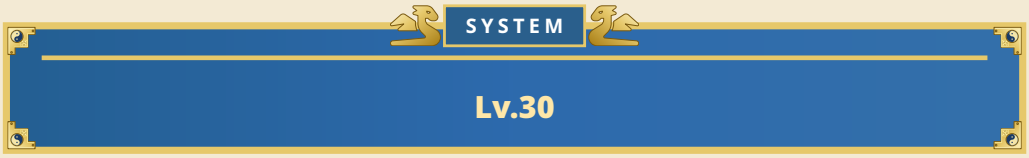
“They’re the Samdo Sect! They’re nothing but Second Rate sect husks! Let us smash them right now and—”

“No.”

“What?”

“They’re not dregs.”

Their sharp aura and murderous eyes were nothing like those of the ordinary martial artists I’d seen from small and mid-sized sects. The System turned my suspicion into certainty.



That was their average Level according to Qi Sense.

Every last one of them was a First Rate martial artist. Damn it. I’d spent three days with these people and hadn’t noticed a thing.

I’d been too fixated on Logout.

That was what I got for letting my guard down. I bit my lip and looked at them—or, more precisely, at the thick grass behind them.

The movement had been extremely faint, but it couldn’t escape my eyes.

Someone’s hiding there.

They were outside the range of Qi Sense, so I couldn’t confirm it, but my instincts told me I was right. Spies, and an ambush on top of that. Thorough bastards.

“You lot. Who are you really?”

“What is that supposed to mean?”

“Where is the real Samdo Sect?”

The Samdo Sect was only a small or mid-sized sect. As Hyuk Mujin had said, they were Second Rate husks. People like these couldn't have been whipped up overnight.

Don't tell me.

"Did you come from the Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

Gwak Jun let out a short laugh.

"The Mount Heng Sword Sect? Well, I suppose you could think that."

Damn it. A third faction.

Logout was right in front of me, and this had to happen now…

Shit. Just my fucking luck.

I was scared shitless. The more I shrank back, the more triumphant Gwak Jun became.

"It's too late for regrets. The grand plan was set in motion long ago."

"Urgh."

Gwak Jun declared in a voice brimming with delight,

"Today… Shanxi Murim will welcome a new master."

Ding.

SYSTEM

— A Quest has been created.

Quest

Slay the Assassins

Someone who has long awaited the right moment has made their move. First, defeat the assassins sent by the traitor!

Grade: Peak

Restriction: Jin Taekyung

Objective: Slay the Assassins (0/20)

Reward: EXP and Fame

Chain Quest

Failure: Death

I blinked. Had I misread the Quest Window?

Twenty?

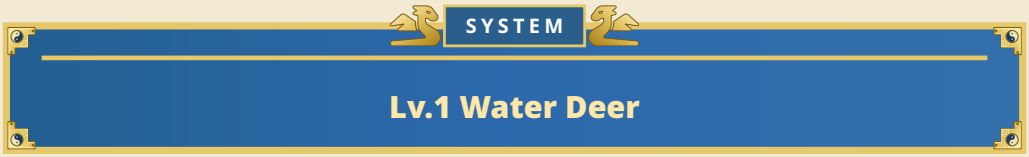
Why twenty? There were enemies lying in ambush back there too.

Just as the question occurred to me, the grass shook. The ambushers charged toward us with a battle cry.

"Kweeeek!"

That was a strange battle cry. No, wait. Wasn't that an animal?

As I stood there blankly, an alert rang in my ears to announce that Qi Sense had activated.



What the hell?

“Water deer?”

A herd of water deer brushed past us and vanished beyond the hill. A sudden appearance. A quick exit.

Gwak Jun drew his sword with an oddly deflated look on his face.

“Attack!”

The twenty enemies approached slowly. Still reeling from the water deer, I called to Hyuk Mujin.

“Hey.”

“What?”

“They’re all First Rate, you know?”

“What? Really?”

Hyuk Mujin jumped.

“Yeah. You know Lee Seogeun, the second son of the Mount Heng Sword Sect? Imagine twenty of him.”

“Twenty Lee Seogeuns?”

His reaction was strange. Hyuk Mujin thought it over for a moment, then tossed out a single remark.

“They’re all going to die, aren’t they?”

Gwak Jun thought,

This isn’t how it was supposed to go.

His gaze was locked on one man. Jin Taekyung, the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, known as a Supreme First Rate martial artist.

Every time his spear moved, blood spurted and Gwak Jun’s men fell.

Even if they weathered one blow, the second or third always finished them. Every one of them was a First Rate martial artist trained for at least ten years.

What the hell is he?

He was clearly a spearman, but he didn’t care whether the gap closed or not. Whenever it looked like there wasn’t even room to swing the spear, daggers and axes popped out from somewhere and stabbed and jabbed at anything in reach.

It put an acrobat troupe's tricks to shame.

Where the hell are all those weapons coming from?

He hadn't even seen them appear. He had no idea what kind of technique it was. This wasn't a matter of martial arts or internal energy.

Jin Taekyung himself was simply strong.

The information was wrong.

Twenty men weren't nearly enough. They should have brought twice that number. According to the information Gwak Jun had received, Jin Taekyung was nothing more and nothing less than a lucky greenhorn.

And what the hell are those men?

The nine said to be Jin Taekyung's subordinates advanced slowly with their backs to one another, paying no attention to what their leader was doing up ahead. Individually, their skills were sorely lacking, but together, they formed an iron wall.

Thud. Crack!

"Gaaah!"

"Stab them! Stab them!"

"Come in! Come in!"

Gwak Jun's lips trembled.

They had no honor as martial artists. In the middle of this melee they piled on three or four at a time and hacked away, and even his First Rate subordinates couldn't avoid ending up as meat on a skewer.

"You bastards…!"

Anger drove out his fear of Jin Taekyung. Just as Gwak Jun, beside himself with fury, was about to hurl himself into the fight—

Whoooosh—

A violent gale erupted at the center of the battlefield.

Jin Taekyung's spear tore through the wind and shattered the swords. Hundreds of sword fragments rode the gale and swept forward, tearing into the owners of those swords and anyone else who failed to react in time.

Pupupupupup!

"…Urk."

Thud.

A martial artist with sword fragments buried all over his body pitched forward. Of the ten or so men caught in One Annihilation, he was the only one who managed even that much of a sound.

"…!"

Someone swallowed hard, their throat bobbing.

For that moment, friend and foe alike fell silent. No one dared even think of raising a sword to fight.

One person was the exception, of course.

“One Annihilation. This thing is awesome.”

The instant Gwak Jun heard that mutter, he gave up on everything.

It’s all over.

Even if the grand plan succeeded, he had failed. All that remained was the meaningless choice between dying to Jin Taekyung and dying to that person.

I have to run. Far away, somewhere no one can find me.

But Gwak Jun never got the chance to leave in search of a second life. Just as he turned, a savage voice stopped him.

“Stay right there if you don’t want to die very painfully.”

Jin Taekyung added in a slightly gentler voice,

“If you answer well, I’ll kill you gently.”

Gwak Jun’s face went white.

Crunch!

“Ghk.”

I felt it.

Two or three ribs had probably broken, and the wind had been knocked clean out of him.

He held up pretty well for a Level 40, but that was his limit.

“I told you not to run.”

“If I were him, I would’ve run too.”

Covered in blood and dust, Hyuk Mujin stared at me like I was some kind of beast.

“If you’re going to tell him you’ll kill him gently, you might as well say you’ll coat your spearhead with Golden Sore Medicine[136] before you stab him.”

“Want me to stab you?”

“Now that I think about it, you’re right. A blade hurts less if it hits you gently, doesn’t it? So I suppose you can die gently. Heh heh. Heh heh heh.”

I smacked him once on the back of the head, then hauled Gwak Jun to his feet.

“Let’s try this again. Who are you?”

Ptooey.

I easily dodged the bloody phlegm. With a high Agility stat, you could even avoid spit flying at you from point-blank range.

That was a useful life hack.

[136] Golden Sore Medicine is a salve for blade wounds.

Of course, I had a useful life hack for Gwak Jun too. For example:

“If you get hit in the solar plexus while your ribs are broken, it hurts a lot.”

Thump.

“Gaaaaah!”

“So? Your answer?”

“S-Samdo Sect.”

When I raised my fist again, Gwak Jun shouted,

“The Samdo Sect! We really are the Samdo Sect! I’m telling you the truth!”

Hyuk Mujin frowned.

“He’s lying. The Samdo Sect was founded thirty years ago. In truth, it’s closer to a martial arts school than a sect. They’re highly respected for taking in wandering orphans and teaching them.”

“So?”

“Couldn’t these bastards have killed all the Samdo Sect’s disciples and taken their places?”

“Taken their places? Pfft.”

A deflating sound escaped Gwak Jun’s mouth. He was laughing.

“You still don’t understand? The Samdo Sect was founded according to that person’s will. As if any of you could have guessed at a grand plan thirty years in the making. Heh heh.”

“Thirty years?”

It was an unimaginably long time. Only a handful of people could have lain low for that many years while plotting to seize Shanxi Province.

Only one person came to mind.

The Head Elder?

Why would he do such a thing?

The Head Elder was the one who had pulled Jin Wikyung to his feet while he blamed himself before the children’s bodies. He was also the one who had halted every political maneuver and actively cooperated.

Thanks to him, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had united and made it this far…

Wait.

My head spun.

Could it be?

“Hyuk Mujin. How many martial artists are there from the small and mid-sized sects that recently joined us?”

“If you add the Samdo Sect and the Gunggui Sect together, well over a hundred.”

“And under the Head Elder?”

“If you mean the Head Elder’s faction, probably close to half the main force… Ah!”

Hyuk Mujin and the reconnaissance-squad members gaped as they grasped the situation.

If my guess was right and the Head Elder was a traitor, everything fit.

Helping Jin Wikyung had been nothing more than preparation for today.

So he could take everything in a single battle.

He had helped Jin Wikyung and united the family's strength for this very day.

Suddenly, I remembered what Gwak Jun had said before the fight.

That one line about Shanxi Province getting a new master. It no longer sounded like nonsense.

The main force is in danger.

I had to tell Jin Wikyung.

"We're moving out. Right now!"

I shouted and was about to turn.

"Already too late."

Gwak Jun grinned, baring his bloodstained teeth.

"Too late for me, too late for you bastards, and too late for the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect. The grand plan has already begun."

At the same time, blood gushed out. From his eyes, nose, and mouth—from every opening.

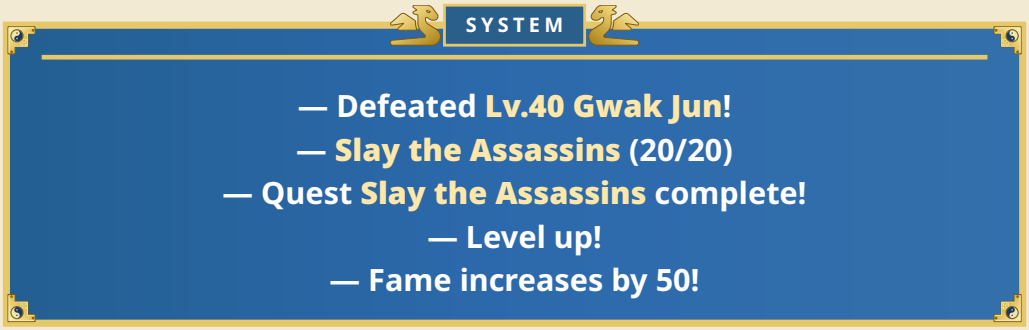
Gwak Jun's head slowly drooped.

Hyuk Mujin spoke with a sickened look on his face.

"He severed his own heart meridian.[137]"

Gwak Jun's death meant one thing.

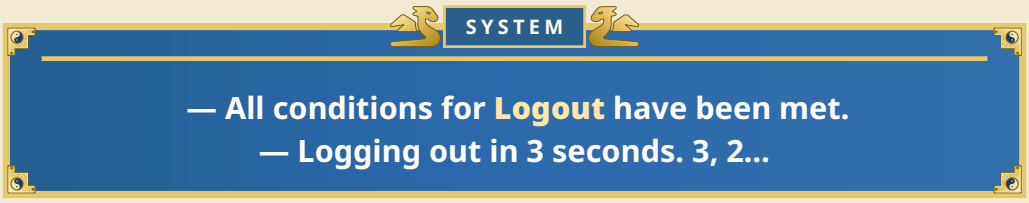
Ding. Ding. Ding.



Quest complete, a level-up, and a Fame increase.

After all those notifications, a single message appeared.

[137] In traditional East Asian medicine, the heart meridian is a pathway associated with the heart.



Strength drained from my whole body. It felt as if I were floating.

Hyuk Mujin caught me, his face filled with alarm.

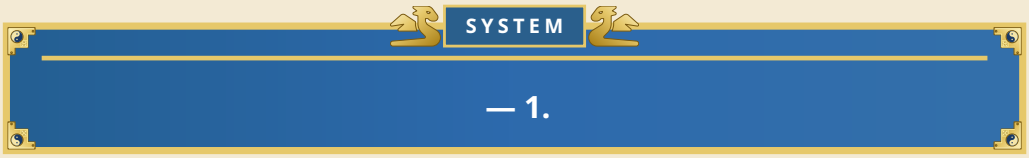
“Captain!”

His voice crackled with static. My vision blurred, and my body slipped beyond my control.

Not now. Not like this...

Of all times.

And then—



Darkness crashed in.

Chapter 39

"Ah."

I blinked. It was hot and humid. When I exhaled, my breath fogged my vision. I felt around my head and touched something hard.

The VR helmet.

I pulled it off, revealing the dusty interior of the capsule.

I sat in the old capsule chair with its worn-flat cushions and waited for my pounding heart to calm down.

Reality? Is this really reality?

Logout after exactly thirty days. Fear surged through me.

Was this really the real world? When I pressed that button and the capsule opened, would I find that too much had changed?

Heart trembling, I opened my mouth.

"Open Status Window."

Silence.

Neither the familiar notification nor the System Window answered.

Only then did it finally sink in.

I had successfully logged out.

"Huuup."

I drew a deep breath and pressed the button. The capsule door opened with a click, and stale air greeted me.

"…Huh."

A dark, cramped room. A small TV on the desk. A single bed. And one person asleep on it, reeking of alcohol.

"Khrrr. Khrrooo."

Who would've thought those bizarre snores could sound so welcome?

I'm back. Back in reality.

Everything was exactly as I remembered it. The last thirty days felt like a dream.

After staring blankly around the room for a while, I walked over to Jinho hyung.[138] Then I slammed the edge of my hand into his uvula.

Whack!

"Khrrr… gack!"

If it hadn't been for this guy's snoring, I never would have crawled into that capsule. I grabbed Jinho tight as he thrashed around.

"Take one more. No, two."

Whack! Whack!

[138] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older man he is close to.

“Gack! Grrrgh!”

“You’re both old enough to know better. Especially you, when you’re supposed to be the goshiwon[139] manager.”

“…Sorry.”

“Let’s not have any more embarrassing scenes, all right?”

Bang.

The door closed. Jinho turned around with a sigh.

“Are you insane?”

Before he could say anything worse, I beat him to the punch.

“For the record, it was self-defense.”

“What the fuck are you talking about? Have you lost your mind?”

“I’m perfectly sane.”

“Then why the hell did you hit someone in the throat while he was sleeping—!”

Thump, thump, thump.

The man next door pounded on the wall. Judging by the rhythm and force, the message was clear: *I want to kill you.*

Jinho lowered his voice.

“Why the hell did you pull that shit? In the middle of the night, too.”

“The middle of the night?”

“Yeah, you lunatic. It’s only three in the morning.”

Jinho held out his phone, looking utterly dumbfounded.

July 25. 3:02 a.m.

I checked the date and time, and my mouth fell open.

Only three hours have passed?

I’d spent a whole month in Murim. Exactly thirty days. Yet only three hours had passed in reality.

“…Hyung.[140]”

“Don’t talk to me. My throat hurts.”

“What’s the usual time ratio for a game capsule?”

“You’re like Hong Gil-dong, you bastard—popping up in the east one moment and the west the next.[141] Even your conversation topics are all over the place.”

“What’s the ratio?”

---

[139] A *goshiwon* is a building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, usually with shared facilities.

[140] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older man he is close to.

[141] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw known for appearing in different places to punish corrupt officials.

“Huh?”

When I asked with a stiff face, Jinho hyung[142] looked briefly flustered, then answered.

“The latest capsule that came out last month can do five to one, I think.”

“What exactly does five to one mean?”

“What do you think? Five hours pass in the game for every hour in reality.”

This was driving me crazy.

“What about anything beyond that?”

“There isn’t anything. Five to one is the limit of current technology… But why are you asking?”

Because something impossible had happened.

How am I supposed to make sense of this?

Even at a second glance, the capsule was ancient. That piece of junk, made more than twenty years ago, had left modern technology in the dust.

Thirty days in only three hours. What kind of time ratio was that? My head was too scrambled even to calculate it.

“That’s insane.”

“What is?”

There was no way I could understand this on my own. Maybe Jinho could come up with some kind of answer.

After a moment’s hesitation, I spoke.

“A month ago—no, three hours ago—I went into that capsule…”

I’d been through so much that there was a lot to tell. Even after hearing the whole story, Jinho remained silent for a long time.

Then he said one thing.

“That’s insane.”

“Exactly. How does any of this make sense? Could that be some illegally modified capsule or something?”

“No. Not the capsule. You.”

“Huh?”

Jinho hyung[143] spoke with a serious face.

“Just own it and apologize. Say, ‘I’m sorry. Your snoring was so loud I hit you.‘ Be cool about it, you bastard.”

“…”

“What, you couldn’t log out and spent a month risking your life in a game? Go write a novel.”

---

[142] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older man he is close to.

[143] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older man he is close to.

Right. I knew that was going too well.

I sighed.

“I’m telling you, it’s true.”

“Come on, Taekyung. Let’s think about this rationally.”

Jinho put on a solemn tone.

“Some guy smacks a sleeping person in the uvula to wake him up, then says he was trapped in a game for a month. But he checks the clock, and only three hours have passed? And the capsule is an antique that belongs in a museum?”

“I know it sounds insane. I get it. But…”

“Then try to get me, too. My head hurts from the hangover, my uvula hurts, and looking at you hurts.”

“No, just listen to me!”

Thump, thump, thump, thump.

Before the man next door could smash through the wall, I lowered my voice.

“Then try it yourself.”

“What?”

“If you try it, you’ll believe me.”

Nothing was faster than experiencing it firsthand. If I pulled him out after about ten minutes, he’d have no choice but to believe me.

Jinho stared hard at me before answering.

“Fine. Let’s try it, then.”

He climbed into the capsule and even put on the VR helmet. As he grumbled about the sour smell inside it, I said,

“I’ll pull you out soon. Stay holed up at Honghwaru.”

“Honghwaru, my ass. Just close the capsule door.”

I was curious to see his face when he came back out. I closed the capsule door, took out my phone, and opened the stopwatch.

The instant I pressed start, the numbers began racing upward.

One second, two seconds… ten seconds.

Ten seconds in reality had to mean minutes, maybe even hours, in the game.

By now, he must be scrambling to figure out what’s going on at Honghwaru…

Clunk.

“Huh?”

The door opened.

What? Why is he already out? No, how did he get out?

Jinho sighed at my bewildered expression.

“What are you doing?”

“Uh… Huh?”

"The power isn't even on. What game were you playing?"

What was that supposed to mean?

"The power isn't on?"

"Move."

While I was still stammering, Jinho climbed out of the capsule, bent down, and picked something up from underneath it.

"What does this look like to you?"

A cord.

An unplugged power cord.

I scrubbed furiously at my eyes, but nothing changed.

Was I seeing things?

"Why is this…"

"Taekyung. Jin Taekyung. You poor, pathetic soul."

Jinho gazed at me with sorrowful eyes.

"Go to a mental hospital as soon as the sun comes up. I'm going back to my room."

He tossed the power cord aside and walked away. I stared blankly after him.

The power cord hadn't even been plugged in.

Then what was the game I played?

I felt as though I'd been bewitched by a ghost. Goose bumps rose all over my body.

I lay on the bed and thought.

Am I crazy?

I'd played a game for thirty days in a capsule that hadn't even been plugged in.

I could understand Jinho's reaction. But everything that had happened there…

It was all real.

Jin Wikyung, Wolhwa, Hyuk Mujin, and the Head Elder. I remembered every NPC's face, their way of speaking, their mannerisms. It hadn't been a delusion I'd cooked up on my own.

Then what was the problem?

There was only one answer.

The problem was the game capsule itself. It had been made twenty-seven years ago—a piece of junk that should have been retired long ago and put in a museum.

Even its date of manufacture was suspicious.

January 1, 2020.

The day the Demon King Asmodeus fell at humanity's hands.

Who the hell was making game capsules back then?

Hundreds of millions had died during the five-year Great War, and monsters had roamed through city centers.

In my opinion, the bastards who heard the breaking news that the Demon King had fallen and fired up a factory going, *All right, let's make game capsules now!* belonged in court.

Back then, I thought it was a misprint.

I froze.

A misprint?

The product manual!

How could I have forgotten something that important? What an idiot.

I shot to my feet and began turning the room upside down. At last, I found the familiar little booklet under the bed.

> **Product User Manual**
> **Product Name:** Virtual Reality Access Device
> **Model Name:** Ark - 2020
> **Manufacturer:** H Soft
> **Date of Manufacture:** January 1, 2020

Then the next page.

> **Precautions**
>
> - The player cannot log out at will.
> - If the player dies during play, resurrection is impossible.

A month ago—no, three hours ago—I had thrown the booklet aside at this point.

This time was different.

With trembling hands, I turned to the last page.

> **Key Features**
>
> - A custom capsule made for one person only! Once a user is registered, the capsule is permanently bound to that user until death.
> - Time-ratio adjustment for comfortable play! Upon login, time in reality passes very slowly. The reverse is also true.
> - Character Synchronization System! By synchronizing with their character, the user experiences a greater sense of unity.

"What the hell is this?"

I could read the words, but my brain refused to process them. I started again from the beginning.

First, permanent binding.

It meant exactly what it said. The capsule was mine until I died. Once I got some answers, I was going to smash the goddamn thing to pieces.

Next, the time ratio.

That was the part I'd been most curious about. But instead of an exact figure, all it gave me was the vague phrase *passes very slowly*.

It said the reverse was also true, so time in the game must be passing very slowly now.

Then is the war still going on?

Jin Wikyung came to mind. The Head Elder's betrayal was already a given, and he would try to stab Wikyung in the back at the critical moment. Had Hyuk Mujin and the reconnaissance squad gotten that news to him?

Right. That's still a long way off. The time ratio reversed.

More importantly, I had immediate problems of my own. I examined the final key feature, but unlike the others, this one made no sense no matter how many times I read it.

Synchronize with a character?

Just to be sure, I even looked it up in a Korean dictionary. It meant exactly what I thought it meant, which only made it sound even crazier.

How the hell do you synchronize with a game character?

I couldn't make any sense of it. In the end, all I'd done was add another question to the pile.

One thing was certain.

I wasn't crazy.

I flopped onto the bed and read the front of the booklet again.

"Manufacturer: H Soft."

In the end, every road led to the same place. If I investigated these bastards, something was bound to turn up.

I searched the internet for H Soft, but aside from a porn studio with the same name, I didn't find a thing.

"…"

First, I needed to lock the door and think.

Chapter 40

I was flying through the sky. With my enormous wings spread wide, I cut through the wind.

Far below lay a high, steep gorge shaped like a bottle gourd. Hundreds of people stood within it.

A man standing at the center shouted at the top of his lungs.

“Don’t fight for the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

Then the ground shook. Trees trembled, and mountain birds took flight.

I glanced behind me. A massive cloud of dust was sweeping through the gorge toward us.

“Fight for yourselves! Fight for your families and the ones you love, before the enemy tramples them!”

He drew his sword and roared.

“Stand and face them like martial artists! I will do the same!”

Hundreds of weapons were drawn in unison. The man strode forward and took the lead. The cloud of dust crossing the gorge scattered, revealing countless people.

“Waaaaah!”

“Wipe out those Jin Family bastards!”

The man suddenly looked up. When he spotted me, he grinned.

“I’ve got a good feeling about this.”

The moment I saw his face, the strength drained from my wings. I plummeted into the depths of my consciousness.

“Pwah! Pwah-pwah!”

I desperately flapped my wings—or rather, my arms—before realizing what had happened.

It was a dream.

Thank god. I thought I was a goner. Only after catching my breath did the situation in the room come into focus.

“This is a breaking news report. A new Gate has appeared at Exit 3 of Hapjeong Station. Magical power measurements have confirmed it as a Grade C Gate, and…”

A small TV sat on the desk, showing an announcer. And then there was—

“What the hell was that?”

[144] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

Jinho hyung[144] stood there with a pot lid in one hand and chopsticks in the other, staring at me like I was out of my mind.

“Some kind of performance art?”

“Shut up. I was dreaming.”

“About swimming?”

“About falling.”

“Good for you. You’ll grow taller.”

He delivered the line without a shred of interest and slurped up his noodles, looking completely at home. For a moment, I wondered if this was even my room.

“This is my room, right?”

“Probably.”

“Then why are you here?”

“Is this anything new?”

That actually sounded plausible. I almost bought it.

“Turn off the TV or something. People are trying to sleep.”

“Some inconsiderate bastard even hits people in the uvula while they’re sleeping.”

“…”

Anyway, that bastard had one hell of a mouth on him.

“If you’ve got nothing to say, eat some ramen. I cooked five packs because I thought you might wake up.”

Talk about foresight. I took the chopsticks from him, overcome with emotion.

This wasn’t just ordinary ramen. It was my first ramen in a month.

The smell that pulled at my appetite. Noodles cooked just right. Broth boiled spicy with separately sliced Cheongyang peppers.

This is insane. Absolutely insane.

Slurp.

By the time I came to my senses, it was all over. Jinho stared blankly as I licked the pot clean.

“I thought you were filming a commercial. Have you never eaten ramen in your life?”

“It’s my first ramen since I came back.”

“Are you still on that?”

“Try eating nothing but Chinese food for a month, then have some ramen. Michelin’s got nothing on this.”

“Stop. It’s not funny anymore.”

He looked thoroughly fed up. This time, though, I had something to back up my story.

“Look this over, then we’ll talk.”

“What’s this?”

“What do you think? A product user manual.”

“…Don’t tell me.”

“Yeah. It was inside that capsule. Read it.”

“Someone left this inside when they threw out a piece of junk more than twenty years old?”

Jinho tilted his head, then started reading. A few seconds later, he looked up.

“This is a misprint. The date of manufacture says January 1, 2020.”

I’d thought the same thing at first.

At first.

“That might not be a printing error.”

“Huh?”

“No, forget it. That’s still just a guess. What about the rest? Have you heard of the model or the manufacturer listed there?”

Jinho was crazy about electronics, especially capsules.

He was a well-known user on all the relevant sites and had even run an IT blog.

But his immediate answer sent my expectations crashing down.

“No.”

Well, that was only natural. Even an internet search hadn’t turned anything up. Still, I couldn’t help feeling a little disappointed.

“You really don’t know? You know this field inside out.”

“Yeah. But I don’t know this.”

Jinho scratched his head.

“An illegally modified capsule? Or maybe a custom job? Honestly, I’ve never seen a design like that.”

The more he talked, the bleaker it sounded.

“Fine, forget the design. But I know every model from the very first to the latest—everything that’s ever been released in Korea.”

“And?”

“The model name written here. The manufacturer. I’ve never seen either of them in my life.”

“Couldn’t it be an overseas manufacturer?”

“Oh, you hopeless idiot. You dumbass. You moron.”

Looking thoroughly exasperated, Jinho thrust the manual at me.

“Read the first line.”

“Product User Manual?”

“Exactly. It’s in Korean. Korean!”

“Oh.”

"Whether H Soft is a domestic company or a foreign one, if they went to the trouble of producing a Korean manual, there's no way I wouldn't know them. It's not like there are hundreds or thousands of capsule manufacturers out there."

I felt like a complete idiot. Not that I knew anything about capsules in the first place.

Then Jinho spoke up.

"Wait a second."

He pulled out his smartphone and started tapping the screen. He seemed to be searching, but the result was obvious.

"Fuck. All I'm getting is porn sites."

Yeah, that one was pretty good.

"It's not even a ghost company. Why is there nothing about it?"

"Read the rest too."

By the time he reached the last page, he'd really feel like he'd been haunted. Jinho turned the pages with a serious expression.

Once.

Then again.

"Isn't it incredible?"

"Yeah. Incredible."

His voice was hollow.

"You told me to look at blank pages. That's incredible."

"Huh?"

"No wonder I thought this manual was so half-assed. No explanation of the capsule's components, no operating instructions, and even the model name, manufacturer, and date of manufacture are a mess."

"Blank pages? What are you talking about?"

"Well, well. Look at this humanities-major bastard playing innocent."

I snatched the manual from him and hurriedly read it.

The contents I'd seen before falling asleep were still there. Precautions on the second page. Key features on the last.

"You can't see this?"

"Knock it off. This is starting to scare me."

That expression. That tone.

He meant it.

The writing I could see was invisible to Jinho.

Or maybe…

Only I can see it.

I remained frozen for a long time.

Pshhh—

I climbed out of the capsule on shaky legs.

Its glossy exterior made it look like a giant egg. This was the latest model, released only last month.

“Oh, you’re out already. Did you try the game I recommended?”

Still half out of my mind, I answered the capsule café owner sitting behind the counter.

“Yes.”

The virtual-reality game he’d recommended was a megahit with ten million concurrent users. He’d said it had incredible graphics, outstanding freedom, and more than seventy percent of the market.

“The graphics are insane, right?”

I logged into the game, saw the graphics, and thought:

Am I the one who’s insane?

This is the most popular virtual-reality game out there?

The graphics were good. I could give it that.

But that was as far as it went.

The NPCs’ faces and movements. Their dialogue patterns. All five senses as I experienced them through my character. All of it felt unnatural.

It was a *game*. It never felt like *reality*.

“Do you have any wuxia[145] games?”

“Ah, so that’s what you’re into? There are quite a few. What’s the title you’re looking for?”

“Murim.”

“Murim Online?”

“No. It’s an open-world game. Single-player.”

“Is there a wuxia game like that?”

Figures.

There was nothing more to hear. I staggered out the door, and the owner called after me.

“Come again!”

I wouldn’t.

Not ever again.

[145] *Wuxia* is a Chinese genre of stories about martial heroes.

Hope Goshiwon.[146]

I sat beneath the old, rusted sign and pulled out my smartphone. The other end picked up almost before it could ring.

Click.

“Yeah. What?”

My one and only nemesis—no, my younger sister, Hayeon.

The moment I heard that uniquely bratty voice of hers, my throat closed up.

“Hello?”

“…Yeah.”

“Why’d you call?”

“Just because. I wanted to hear your voice.”

A deathly silence followed.

“I’m hanging up.”

“No, wait. Wait!”

“You have three seconds. What do you want?”

That damn girl…

Right. This was Jin Hayeon.

Thanks to her, my tear ducts, which had gotten a little moist, dried out like the sand around the pyramids.

“What’s Mom doing?”

“She went out on an errand. Call her if you’re curious.”

I deliberately hadn’t called her. Hearing this brat’s voice was already enough to choke me up. If I heard Mom’s, I might start bawling like a little kid.

I quickly changed the subject.

“What about you?”

“What do you think a high-school senior with a hundred and twenty days left until the college entrance exam is doing? Studying.”

Her tone was sharper than usual. Exam stress must have been getting to her.

“How’s studying going?”

“I bombed the July mock exam. I didn’t manage my condition right and missed even the easy questions. God, the more I think about it, the more annoyed I get.”

“It’s fine. Just do well on the real thing. How many did you miss?”

“Two.”

“That’s still Grade 1.[147] What about the other subjects?”

“Two across all subjects.”

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[146] A *goshiwon* is a low-cost Korean boarding house consisting of extremely small private rooms with shared facilities.

[147] Korean exam grades use a 1–9 scale, with Grade 1 the highest.

"Huh?"

"One in Korean history and one in math."

"…Two total? Across every subject? Are you serious?"

"Obviously that's what I meant."

Smart little brat…

I knew she was good at studying, but I hadn't realized she was this good. Thinking back on my own school grades, it really seemed like there was such a thing as dumping all the genes into one kid.

"You're pretty good at this studying thing, huh?"

"From your perspective, aren't I amazing?"

"W-what kind of nonsense is that? I was pretty good at studying too, you know. You just don't remember because you were in elementary school…"

"Last week during a deep clean, I found your report card. There were so many Grade 7s[148] I thought it was a slot machine that had hit the jackpot."

"You need some allowance, right? How much does makeup cost these days?"

"That's pathetic. Seriously."

Cruel girl…

The call lasted more than ten minutes. I mostly listened.

Hayeon rattled on about studying, school, and a boy she was interested in. Her voice had grown much brighter than when we first started talking.

I found myself getting oddly sentimental.

I really did come back.

Had I been dreaming? Or had I lost myself in some delusion?

Only a day had passed in reality, yet utterly incomprehensible, inexplicable things had happened.

But I decided not to try to understand them anymore.

I'm back in reality now.

And this was where I had to live.

My family was here. I was here. That was enough.

I'd simply had a strange dream for a little while. The kind of dream that would naturally fade with time.

"So I…"

"Yeah."

Listening to my little sister chatter, I got to my feet.

It was time to leave the old, rusted sign behind and return to my room.

[148] Korean exam grades use a 1–9 scale, with Grade 1 the highest.

Bzzzt. Bzzzt.

Seong Jinho cracked open his bleary eyes. The smartphone beside his pillow was ringing.

Six in the morning.

The signal that his day had begun.

“Oh, I’m dying.”

It had been five years since he left home. By now, the moldy smell that crept into his nose every morning had become thoroughly familiar.

Eyes half closed, Seong Jinho shoved his cigarettes and lighter into his pocket and left the room.

Nothing wakes you up like a cigarette.

He shuffled up to the rooftop in his slippers. Just as he put a cigarette between his lips—

Thud.

“Huh?”

What was that?

He leaned over the railing and spotted a hunk of metal in the recycling area directly below.

He also saw the well-built young man standing there, staring at it.

“Hey! Jin Taekyung!”

At Seong Jinho’s shout, Jin Taekyung looked up.

“What?”

“You throwing that away?”

The hunk of metal was the junk capsule Taekyung had picked up the day before. After pulling that ridiculous prank with it, he seemed to be taking it right back out to the trash.

He was awfully serious for a prank, though… Ah, whatever. It was all nonsense.

Seong Jinho let out a short laugh.

“Why throw it away? Aren’t you going back to Murim?”

“You believed that?”

Jin Taekyung smiled back. But to Seong Jinho, who had watched him for a long time, the smile looked somehow awkward.

What’s with him?

Something felt off.

Jin Taekyung waved to the uneasy Seong Jinho and started down the hill.

“Where are you going, you punk? Aren’t we having breakfast together later?”

“I have to work!”

Jin Taekyung left without looking back. Seong Jinho took a drag from his half-smoked cigarette.

“That bastard really works hard…”

Soon, Jin Taekyung disappeared from sight.

Seong Jinho stubbed out his cigarette in a flowerpot and was about to leave when the junk capsule caught his eye.

He said the manufacturer was H Soft, right?

It was probably just some half-assed prank, but there was no harm in looking into it.

Chapter 41

The Hunter Manpower Office.

They called it an office, but it occupied an entire six-story building on prime real estate right by the station. Hundreds of Hunters passed through its doors every day.

It's been a while.

Even at dawn, the lobby was packed.

After waiting through the long line, I reached the counter. The woman behind it asked in a businesslike tone,

"Is this your first time at the manpower office?"

"No. I'm already registered."

"Your name?"

"Jin Taekyung."

Back when I was a rookie, I'd graduated from the Hunter Training Center with excellent scores. But hardly anyone needed an F-rank Hunter like me, and the contracts a few small and midsize Guilds offered as if they were doing me a favor were highway robbery.

So I'd come here instead. To a different branch, though.

"There's a record at the Ilsan branch. I've put you on the list, so please wait in the hall on the first floor."

"Yes."

This six-story building was a pyramid unto itself. The first floor took E- and F-ranks. You needed to be at least D-rank to set foot on the second.

Some people got angry and asked if that wasn't blatant discrimination.

It was.

Not like this was the first or second time.

I'd lasted seven years in this business and seen every ugly side of it. I'd long since passed the point where I could afford to be picky.

I had just started walking when—

"Hey, look who it is!"

I turned toward the gravelly voice. Some hairy guy was grinning at me.

"Taekyung. You're Jin Taekyung, right?"

"Uncle Kkeokjeong?"

This guy's still alive?

His surname was Im. I'd forgotten his given name. I was pretty sure I'd heard it once, when he introduced himself seven years ago, but I couldn't remember it.

He looked so much like a bandit that everyone called him Im Kkeokjeong.[149]

"How've you been all this time?"

"Life as an F-rank Hunter is pretty much the same for all of us. How about you?"

"Don't call me uncle."

Im Kkeokjeong gave me an easy smile.

"Call me hyung.[150] We're not even that far apart in age."

How many years apart were we again? I couldn't quite remember.

"Hyung,[151] how old are you?"

"Forty-five."

"…"

What's with that confidence?

But the social skills I'd honed over the years came through for me. I somehow managed to force a smile.

"You're right. I'll just call you hyung.[152]"

"That's it, little brother. Hahahaha!"

His hearty laughter rang through the hall. Nearly a hundred people looked over, then turned away.

I should've just pretended I didn't hear him and kept walking.

Ours wasn't exactly a deep connection. We'd seen each other almost every day for about half a year at the Ilsan office and worked together a few times. That was about it.

He's a good guy, but…

Sometimes it was embarrassing to be around him.

Like now.

"The yulmu tea[153] here is incredible. The chairs in the hall are nice and soft too."

Im Kkeokjeong tossed back his yulmu tea[154] in one gulp and leaned his chair as far back as it would go.

Judging by how comfortable he looked, this clearly wasn't his first or second visit.

"You come here often?"

"Not every day. I drop by now and then. Once I got married and had kids, I started being more careful. Heh heh."

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[149] Im Kkeokjeong was a famous Joseon-era bandit and folk hero; the nickname comes from the man's bandit-like appearance.

[150] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

[151] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

[152] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

[153] Yulmu tea is a Korean grain drink made from Job's tears.

[154] Yulmu tea is a Korean grain drink made from Job's tears.

Apparently, he'd started a family while we were out of touch. When I congratulated him, Im Kkeokjeong scratched his head.

"What's so special about that?"

He was being modest, but a big deal was a big deal. He'd worked as a Hunter—an F-rank Hunter—for more than twenty years and still managed to build a family.

I wondered if the Im Kkeokjeong in front of me might be my future self.

Assuming I live to that age.

Being a Hunter wasn't a career you could keep up for long. Plenty of people retired the moment they completed the ten years needed to qualify for a pension.

"Anyway, you're starting to look the part. When I first met you, you were so nervous you could barely talk."

"Of course. I've got seven years under my belt now."

"So you've been bouncing around manpower offices ever since? Didn't you sign a fairly decent contract with some small or midsize Guild? So, So… what was it called again?"

"Sopung Guild. They fired me the day before yesterday."

Im Kkeokjeong forced a laugh.

"Hahaha! Good for you. The Guild's name was lousy anyway. Sopung? What kind of name is that? It's not like you're going on a picnic to a Gate."

"No, not that kind of sopung. It's a place name. They're near Bucheon Sopung Terminal, so they're called Sopung Guild."

"Oh…"

The conversation that followed was surprisingly useful. Im Kkeokjeong was a regular at the manpower office, after all, and a veteran Hunter with good information and plenty of hard-earned tricks of the trade.

"The office takes a ten percent commission. That's standard. But this branch has a pretty good batting average."

Batting average was industry slang for your odds of getting hired. For someone whose immediate goal was a day's pay, that was good news.

"Even for F-rank Hunters like us?"

"Huh? Yeah. That's right."

What's with that awkward look?

Before I could ask anything else, a voice came through the speakers in the hall.

"E-rank Hunter Im Hyeokjun. Im Hyeokjun, please come to the lobby."

Six thirty in the morning.

At last, the first batter was up. My turn would come only after all the E-rank Hunters had gone.

"E-ranks first, as expected… Hyung,[155] where are you going?"

"I'll go on ahead."

Im Kkeokjeong—or rather, Im Hyeokjun—slung a large bag of armor and weapons over his shoulder and chuckled.

No wonder his expression looked off.

He must have worked himself to the bone while we were out of touch.

It was only a single step up, but advancing beyond F-rank despite an F-rank's potential was no easy feat.

"See you around."

"Yeah. See you."

His departure from the hall opened the floodgates. The speakers began rattling off names one after another.

E-rank so-and-so, E-rank somebody else, E-rank…

Goddamn it, am I the only F-rank here?

Just as I was starting to get anxious—

"F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung, please come to the lobby."

There it is!

"Mr. Jin Taekyung?"

A man in a white linen shirt was waiting in the lobby. Without so much as a greeting, he held out a contract, his expression flat.

"I'm from the Peace Guild. Read it and sign."

This guy's tone is seriously irritating.

I glared from the contract to the man's face and back.

"The settlement split is eight to two."

"After the raid, the proceeds will be distributed fairly according to contribution. We'll take twenty percent of your share."

"And the base pay?"

"Thirty."

"Thir…ty?"

Did this guy lose half his tongue?

"Gate rank?"

"E-rank."

"Rejected."

"The combat positions are full. You'll be a porter."

[155] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

The corner of my eye twitched.

What the hell did this guy just say?

“A por-ter?”

“Is there a problem?”

“Obviously.”

The man in the linen shirt glared down his nose at me.

“What is it?”

“I don’t have a pen.”

“…”

After a brief silence, I took the pen he handed me and scrawled my signature. The base pay was 300,000 won,[156] and the settlement split was generous too.

I’d flinched when I heard it was an E-rank Gate, but I was only going as a porter, so it didn’t matter. I’d skin a few monsters, haul a pack around, then part ways with everyone in a good mood.

Peace Guild. I like the name already.

I’d been itching to sign so badly my fingers had almost cramped.

“All done.”

“…”

“So where are we going? Are we taking a van?”

“There’s one waiting outside.”

“Oh, that one? Looks nice. Bet the AC works great too.”

“…”

“Guess I was the last one. There are already a few people here… Huh? Kkeokjeong hyung![157]”

“Huh? Taekyung!”

Im Kkeokjeong was waiting to load his bags into the bus’s trunk. He grinned wide.

“You’re coming too. That’s great!”

“Looks like you and I really do have a connection, hyung.[158]”

“Hahahaha!”

“Ahahaha!”

“…Let’s get going.”

Maybe it was the heat, but the man in the linen shirt suddenly looked years older.

[156] 300,000 Korean won is about $210 or €190 at the project rates.

[157] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

[158] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

The bus pulled out. From the passenger seat, the shirt guy said we'd arrive within twenty minutes, then closed his eyes.

Im Kkeokjeong introduced me to the others who'd been hired with us.

"All right, everyone, say hello. This is a younger friend of mine."

Now that I looked, they all knew each other. I dipped my head.

"Hello. I'm Jin Taekyung."

"Oh, nice to meet you."

"Tall, handsome young fellow. Looks like he can fight."

There were three new faces, all men in their late thirties or early forties. As the warm introductions continued, Im Kkeokjeong explained.

"These guys are all E-rank. I've known them for a long time. More than ten years now."

"Yeah, about that long. Time sure flies."

That meant every one of them had at least ten years of experience. I'd been around long enough that nobody would call me a rookie, but these guys were on another level.

A whole party of old-timers.

People like them pulled their weight wherever they went. In an emergency, they were far more dependable than some half-baked D-rank.

"So what rank are you, young man?"

Here it came. The rank check.

I answered carefully.

"F-rank."

"Ah. That so? How long have you been at it?"

"Seven years."

"Hmm. That so?"

The mood went lukewarm. If my first raid started like this, that would be a problem.

I ran my mouth before it could settle.

"I won't be taking part in combat. I'm joining as a porter, so you don't need to worry…"

The three men stared blankly at me.

"Why the long explanation? You think we're going to eat you?"

"Drop it. If he's been knocking around for seven years, he knows enough."

"If Kkeokjeong hyung[159] recommended him, that's good enough. Team Leader Choi must've thought he was all right too, or he wouldn't have agreed."

Recommended? Team Leader Choi?

[159] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

I didn't know the exact details, but I could more or less piece together what had happened.

Im Kkeokjeong had recommended me to the man in the linen shirt—Team Leader Choi.

"W-what are you talking about?"

Im Kkeokjeong waved his hands, his face turning bright red.

The three men snickered.

"It's written all over your face. How did this hyung[160] ever manage to get married?"

"Good deeds are supposed to come to light. Why hide them?"

"Exactly. You think so too, don't you?"

I nodded at once.

"Of course. Thank you for looking out for me."

"Ahem. I just put in a word. Team Leader Choi made the decision."

Well, then…

I'd thought of Im Kkeokjeong as one of the countless people I'd briefly crossed paths with and then moved on from. Meeting him again, I realized he was far more guileless and warmhearted than I'd expected.

So that's why the terms were so generous.

Judging by the way they kept mentioning Team Leader Choi, I figured their friendship had played a part in my contract too.

"I'll work hard."

"I told you, Team Leader Choi made the decision!"

The man in question answered Im Kkeokjeong's awkward excuse.

"Then let's say I made the decision."

The man in the linen shirt had opened his eyes at some point. No—Team Leader Choi. He addressed us.

"We're here."

I turned my head. A four-meter-high[161] Gate loomed closer. At its center, a vortex of magical power churned, ready to suck us in.

An E-rank Gate.

My first raid since coming back.

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[160] *Hyung* is a familiar form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him.

[161] Four meters is about 13 ft.

Chapter 42

A Gate.

The greatest mark left by the Great Cataclysm.

More than thirty years ago, Demon King Asmodeus had used Gates as invasion routes. They had long since become a means for Hunters to make a living and excavation sites for Magic Gems, a higher-dimensional energy resource.

“You’re with the Peace Guild, correct?”

A middle-aged man in work clothes approached us from the entrance.

He was a civil servant with the Gate Management Office, which stationed officials at every Gate.

“Yes.”

The official nodded at Team Leader Choi’s curt reply.

“You’re right on time. When will you be entering?”

“We’ll gear up and go straight in.”

“There’s a waiting room on the second floor. Come back down once you’re ready. Well, then.”

We followed Team Leader Choi inside. The two-story building housing the Management Office was as run-down as they came, and the waiting room wasn’t much better.

Holy shit. That smell.

The moment we opened the door, the stench of sweat hit me. Rusty cabinets and an overflowing trash can jumped out at me too.

“This place is awful. Don’t they ever air it out?”

“That’s Gate officials for you. There’s a reason everyone calls this a cushy posting.”

I left the grumbling behind and started changing into my raid gear. Leather armor and lightweight combat boots. Last, I drew a spear from its long case and gripped it.

It’s been a while.

The way it fit snugly in my hand felt both familiar and strange.

It was definitely different from the weapon I’d used for the past month…

No. Never mind. I shouldn’t think about that anymore.

I have to forget all of it now.

I was tightening the perfectly fine laces on my combat boots for no reason when Im Kkeokjeong came over.

Clad in full-body armor and carrying an enormous tower shield, he looked every bit the main tank.

“All ready?”

"Yeah. Pretty much."

Im Kkeokjeong looked me up and down, then clicked his tongue.

"Look at this guy. How old is that equipment, even?"

"Who knows? I bought it when I first started, so at least seven years?"

Back when I was a rookie, I'd taken the plunge and bought it from an underground shop in Dongdaemun.[162] I still remembered the exact price.

1.98 million won.[163]

I could barely sleep for days after buying it.

Hunters earned a lot, but they spent a lot too, and most of those expenses went toward equipment. It was all because of the unique nature of Gates.

Equipment that isn't imbued with mana or magical power breaks down in no time.

So the most common method was to craft equipment from Magic Gems taken from Gate monsters.

The higher the Grade of the Magic Gem, the more the price shot through the roof.

"Seven years? Good grief. Saving money is all well and good, but you've got to spend it when it counts. You really want to pinch pennies when your life's on the line?"

"Hmm. I had my reasons."

Reasons I didn't particularly want to discuss. Im Kkeokjeong spoke in a concerned voice.

"You're in a noncombat position today, so you should be fine… but be careful."

"I will."

His words left me with a strange feeling. They reminded me of someone who, until recently, had constantly been telling me to be careful.

But the sentimentality didn't last.

"Is everyone ready?"

Team Leader Choi appeared, and my jaw dropped.

No way.

"Is that a Red Drake leather set?"

"Hmm."

Team Leader Choi's face stiffened. I'd only ever seen gear like that in luxury catalogs, and the words had slipped out before I could stop them.

"Ah, sorry…"

"It's nothing special. It was merely crafted using five types of magic and B-grade Magic Gems."

"…"

---

[162] Dongdaemun is Seoul's major wholesale-market district.

[163] 1.98 million won is about $1,400 or €1,300.

“Not that I’m emphasizing the point, but its materials include five types of magic and B-grade Magic Gems.”

“Ah. Right.”

“Red Drake leather is popular for its distinctive sheen, but it only looks impressive. It isn’t particularly useful.”

Team Leader Choi moved, his face still stiff. A faint red glow flashed across him.

“But it is exceptionally beautiful.”

“…”

“Let’s head downstairs.”

Team Leader Choi left the waiting room first. Im Kkeokjeong sidled over to me.

“That guy loves it when someone recognizes his equipment.”

“I mean, I get that, but… what’s with him?”

“No idea. He’s an equipment nut. There’s even a rumor that he blew his entire fortune on that set and sleeps in it every night.”

So that bastard’s a nutjob too.

I sighed inwardly and prayed that today’s raid would end without incident.

“This isn’t the same number of people you registered.”

The civil servant looked uncomfortable. Fair enough. We were supposed to enter soon, and the party still wasn’t all there.

How much longer are we supposed to wait?

Only six people had gathered in front of the Gate. Excluding me, the porter, that left just five combatants.

Since this was an E-rank Gate, we needed at least five more Hunters of the same rank… but those Peace Guild bastards were nowhere in sight. No wonder the official was annoyed.

“You should’ve notified us in advance if you were adding personnel.”

Huh? What did he just say?

Adding personnel?

“I’m sorry.”

At Team Leader Choi’s curt apology, the official picked up his pen and drew several lines through the paperwork.

“It’s not a major problem since we can amend it… but please be more careful next time.”

“Yes.”

Not a major problem, my ass. There aren’t any people!

I poked Im Kkeokjeong in the ribs.

"Hyung.[164] When are the others getting here?"

"What others?"

"The Peace Guild members."

"Team Leader Choi's right there."

"What?"

"Oh, did I forget to tell you? The Peace Guild is new, so it doesn't have many people. There are only three of us, including the Guild Master. Hahaha!"

…You're laughing?

"Come on, hyung.[165]"

"I know, punk. But you don't need to worry."

Im Kkeokjeong patted my shoulder and pointed at Team Leader Choi, who was signing the paperwork.

"That man's a C-rank Hunter."

"Oh. C-rank…"

I shut my mouth.

If Team Leader Choi was a C-rank Hunter, there was no problem. No, he was far better than ten E-rank Hunters. He was a mid-rank Hunter, in a completely different league from a low-rank Hunter like me.

I should've realized the moment I saw him wearing that luxury gear.

The man was walking around with a high-end apartment wrapped around his body. Most low-rank Hunters couldn't afford armor like that even if they cleaned out their entire fortunes ten times over.

A faint halo seemed to shine around Team Leader Choi's back.

"Please verify the signature."

Even the way he handed the pen back to the official looked elegant.

Every little movement seemed to ooze wealth.

So this is the dignity of a C-rank Hunter.

That's fucking cool.

I wanted to become sworn brothers with him. To pledge brotherhood beneath the Gate—a gay oath, no, a Gate oath.

"All right, then. Let's go in… What is it?"

Team Leader Choi looked at me, startled.

"No. I just thought you looked cool."

"Excuse me?"

"Your equipment. I said it looks cool."

At that moment, the corner of Team Leader Choi's mouth twitched.

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[164] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man he is close to.

[165] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man he is close to.

“It’s nothing special. It was merely crafted using five types of magic and B-grade Magic Gems…”

A nutjob I wanted to befriend.

I stepped toward the Gate.

Whoosh—

A familiar sensation enveloped me. The cool, viscous energy unique to magical power.

Then the scenery changed.

“It’s a cave.”

Just as Team Leader Choi said, the raid site was a cave. The moisture-laden walls were damp, and a faint darkness shrouded our surroundings.

“Mr. Taekyung. Take out a flashlight.”

“Yes.”

I quickly set down my backpack. It was a porter’s bag Team Leader Choi had handed me just before we entered the Gate. It looked ordinary on the outside, but it was an expensive item enchanted with both space expansion and weight-reduction magic.

“Here’s the flashlight.”

I handed it over as requested, though in my experience, flashlights weren’t the best option. They were convenient, but if the light suddenly went out, your eyes wouldn’t be adjusted to the darkness.

It was much better to wait a little and let your eyes get used to the darkness…

Click.

“Let there be light. Light.”

Whoosh. A ball of light the size of a soccer ball shot from the flashlight and plastered itself against the cave ceiling.

“…Magic?”

“It has a built-in spell that activates as soon as the incantation is spoken. It lasts quite a while, so it should be good for another three or four hours. It’s a limited-edition item I purchased from Company M…”

Im Kkeokjeong summed it up.

“It’s crazy expensive.”

Was it my imagination, or had Team Leader Choi’s face darkened slightly? Maybe it was just the shadows.

Either way, the raid had become much easier thanks to him.

Money really is the best.

Capital ruled the world, and Gates were no exception. People with money fought in comfort using enchanted equipment. People without it carried torches.

"Take your positions."

At Team Leader Choi's command, everyone moved at once. Im Kkeokjeong and another E-rank Hunter took the lead as tanks, with Team Leader Choi behind them. I, the porter, and the two ranged dealers stood at the very back.

"Move."

We began advancing slowly.

The bright magical light illuminated the path ahead.

"…"

I want one.

"Kiiiieet!"

The creatures crouching in the darkness emerged with shrill cries. Green skin, squat bodies, and grotesque limbs.

They were Hobgoblins, an evolved form of ordinary goblin.

About thirty of them.

With only five combatants, this would be a difficult fight.

But having a C-rank Hunter changes everything.

On top of that, the other four were veteran E-rank Hunters with at least ten-odd years of experience each.

I hung well back and watched the battle.

"Ranged!"

Arrows flew the instant Team Leader Choi gave the order.

One shot, one kill.

The arrows buried themselves in vital points, dropping the unshielded Hobgoblins one after another.

"Kiit!"

"Oh, look. Shield-bearers. What do we do?"

"Hold."

Team Leader Choi issued his next command.

"Tanks, advance."

The tanks moved forward in thick full-body armor, tower shields raised. Im Kkeokjeong and the other man were both hulking giants over 190 centimeters[166] tall. The sight of them alone was intimidating.

"Kiiiieet!"

[166] 190 centimeters is about 6 ft 3 in.

But monsters were monsters for a reason. Trusting in their numbers, the Hobgoblins charged like a swarm of bees.

But—

"Well, look at you."

Bam!

The big, beautiful tower shields sent them flying back as bloody pulp. Seizing the momentum, Im Kkeokjeong swung his mace like a flyswatter, shattering limbs and crushing skulls with every blow.

"You punk! You punk!"

…What was this, whack-a-mole?

Veterans, all right.

All four of them stayed within their roles without overextending themselves, steadily whittling down the enemy numbers.

Knowing when to fall back and when to push in was combat intelligence born of plenty of experience.

"Everyone, hold your positions."

And then one man.

The man who had been directing the flow of battle until now moved.

"I'll take care of the rest."

A red streak flashed across his armor as he plunged into the twenty remaining Hobgoblins.

Slash—

A head soared into the air along a clean arc. It happened so quickly that the monsters couldn't even react.

"Kiiie?"

Slash. Slash. Slash.

The blade never stopped. Merciless and efficient, it pierced and severed one vital point after another.

This was no longer a battle.

It was a massacre—one man slaughtering more than twenty monsters.

So this is a C-rank Hunter.

His speed. His strength.

I could see it all. And I could feel it.

He really is strong.

As a mere F-rank, I couldn't even dream of matching him. He was a mid-rank Hunter, three full ranks above me. A broad river and a towering wall that effort alone could never overcome.

Yet at the same time, a question arose.

What if this were Murim?

Team Leader Choi was unquestionably strong. He had the abilities befitting a C-rank Hunter and plenty of experience.

But if this were Murim… if he were a martial artist…

I'd be stronger.

His movements were fast and powerful, but that was all. He hadn't learned martial arts, nor did he use his mana efficiently.

At best, he was First Rate. In Murim, that was exactly where he would stand.

But this is reality.

I bit my lip without realizing it.

A mid-rank Hunter and a bottom-rank Hunter.

While the mid-rank Hunter wore expensive equipment and slaughtered monsters, the lowest-rank Hunter could only stare blankly.

As a porter.

"Kiiieet…"

The last Hobgoblin fell. Team Leader Choi pulled his sword from its chest, and our eyes met.

"Mr. Taekyung. Please handle the byproducts."

"…"

"Mr. Taekyung?"

I wanted to tell him that I was stronger than him.

But in the end, I couldn't. Because this was my reality.

"…Thank you for your hard work."

I *used to be* stronger than you.

Chapter 43

Slice.

A razor-sharp dagger sank into a Hobgoblin corpse.

Fluids splattered and a foul stench filled the air, but I didn't stop. I discarded the heads, neatly cut the hides from their backs and bellies, and stacked them in a pile.

"You're quite skilled."

"…Thank you."

It was Team Leader Choi. The kindness in his voice made me feel guilty. How childish was I, getting jealous of someone like him?

Especially when I'd dragged up an illusion I'd already decided to forget.

What am I, going through puberty?

I finished the job with my face burning red.

A little over ten minutes, so about twenty seconds per corpse? Even Im Kkeokjeong sidled over, drawn by the speed, and his mouth fell open.

"Damn, have you been doing nothing but this?"

"Plenty of people can do this much."

"Plenty, my ass. You're a total professional."

Hmm. That made me a little proud.

I'd played modest a second ago, but Im Kkeokjeong was right. There weren't many Hunters who could butcher this cleanly at this speed.

"I'm just fast with my hands."

I'd worked factory jobs back in school. I'd even glued eyes onto dolls. In a way, I'd started doing this kind of work before I ever became a Hunter.

"I kept it up during raids, too."

"You switched over to doing this full-time?"

"No. I did both. It was a side job."

"A side job?"

Team Leader Choi, who'd been listening quietly, cut in.

"Uh, yes."

"What exactly did you do?"

"I'd use the breaks after each fight to process the corpses."

"Do you receive additional pay?"

"Of course. It's still work."

"How long have you been doing it?"

"The whole time. From the beginning until now."

Im Kkeokjeong was floored.

"You relentless bastard. I couldn't do it."

“You get used to it. It helps build stamina, too.”

“Your life’s on the line, and you’re building stamina? Hahaha. Team Leader Choi, didn’t I tell you? There’s nobody who works as relentlessly as this kid.”

You told him that?

“Hmm.”

Instead of answering, Team Leader Choi studied me for a moment, then turned away.

“Now that the work is done, shall we get moving again?”

What was that reaction supposed to mean? As I stood there bewildered, Im Kkeokjeong gave me an unreadable smile.

“Keep working hard.”

No, seriously. What’s going on?

The raid went smoothly. The E-rank Hunters had fought together for so long that they moved as one. Once they thinned out the monsters, Team Leader Choi took over.

Slash—

Every swing of his sword sent up a fountain of blood.

I watched every second of the battle unfolding before me.

He really can fight.

Of course, I couldn’t help thinking about Murim.

I’d seen real martial arts with my own eyes—and even learned them. Not the dance-like moves I practiced in the city park at dawn.

…Wait.

No way. But what if?

It was ridiculous. There was no way it would work, but I could at least try.

It won’t work. It won’t… but it would be nice if it did.

Just as I was about to cautiously take a step—

“Mr. Taekyung. Please handle the cleanup.”

Team Leader Choi’s voice snapped me back to my senses.

I’ve completely lost it.

I’d let myself get distracted in the middle of a raid.

Get a grip.

Whatever I wanted to try later, the raid came first for now.

That was the least courtesy I owed my teammates—and the principle that would keep me alive.

“Yes. Coming!”

I ran over like the wind and started taking the corpses apart.

Team Leader Choi and Im Kkeokjeong hovered nearby throughout the entire break, as if they weren't tired at all.

This is seriously getting on my nerves.

Im Kkeokjeong came over again at the next break, right on cue.

"Taekyung. How long have you been using a spear?"

"Seven years."

"Wow. That practically makes you a master. A real master."

"…?"

He came back during the break after that, too.

"Taekyung. You said you graduated top of your training class, right?"

"Yes. But I was only first among the F-ranks, so it doesn't mean much."

"You punk. That's still impressive. I graduated dead last."

"You're impressive too, hyung.[167] But I need to get back to work."

"Oh, right."

Then he came back during the next break, and the next, and the one after that.

"Taekyung. Taekyung. Taekyung."

"Hyung,[168] I think my cochlea just ruptured."

"How many years did you say you worked at your old Guild?"

"Ah."

I wanted to switch classes and become a mage right then and there, just so I could cast a silence spell on the man's mouth.

This is driving me crazy.

There was only one way out: finish the work before blood actually started pouring from my ears. I clenched my teeth and kept my hands moving.

Slice. Slice. Slice.

"Taekyung."

Save me.

I sent a distress signal to Team Leader Choi, who was sitting nearby, but he answered by quietly slipping away.

"The work's done."

[167] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

[168] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

I stood and shouldered the bag, now noticeably heavier than before. Hobgoblins were generous monsters. Poison-resistant hides, a few usable weapons—and they had even dropped two E-grade Magic Gems.

The hides are in good condition, and there are two Magic Gems. This could be worth a decent amount.

Team Leader Choi had contributed the most, so he'd probably take about half. But with so few people, it was still a profitable deal for the other team members.

Not me, of course. According to the contract, the 300,000-won[169] base pay was all I would get.

If he's in a good mood, maybe he'll throw in a little extra.

Team Leader Choi was a fairly generous employer. He was a C-rank Hunter far beyond my level, yet he always spoke to me politely. His personality was a little unusual, but by the standards of this industry, he was practically a saint.

And he's skilled enough to trust.

Thanks to him, we'd made it this far at a steady, rapid pace.

Only the final section of the Gate remained.

The Boss Zone.

If we opened the stone gate in front of us, the Gate's boss monster and the mana field that would send us outside should be waiting beyond it.

"Man, all that work made me hungry."

"Let's finish this quick and go get some gukbap.[170] Taekyung, you're coming too, right? You too, Team Leader Choi."

"No, thank you. I'll order sushi separately."

"…"

Talking about food with the Boss Zone right in front of us. And then there was the guy planning to order sushi by himself.

Should we really be this relaxed?

Of course, I had no room to talk. I'd already earned a full day's pay just by carrying luggage and butchering monsters between fights.

Until I found a job with a new Guild, I couldn't ask for anything more than Team Leader Choi calling me regularly. A sweet gig like this? I'd do it a hundred times over.

"Well, shall we head in?"

"Yes."

At Team Leader Choi's answer, Im Kkeokjeong slammed his tower shield into the stone gate.

Boom!

---

[169] 300,000 Korean won is about $210 or €190.

[170] Gukbap is a Korean dish of rice served in hot soup.

The gate blew apart, and stone dust and dirt poured down. I followed the others into the Boss Zone.

And there…

—Keuruk.

It stood.

A shaman?

That was the first word that came to mind.

An old Hobgoblin wearing a robe covered in strange patterns. It held a withered staff in one hand and a sharp dagger in the other.

—Karruk. Chwi. Akto.

Despite the deafening crash of the doors breaking apart, it continued muttering without so much as a glance our way. With each syllable, black energy rose from the corpses scattered around it.

Wait. Corpses?

I hadn't imagined it. Nearly a hundred dead Hobgoblins lay sprawled across the altar. Looking closer, they were the monsters we should have been fighting in the Boss Zone.

What the hell is going on?

Everyone, myself included, froze at the unfamiliar sight.

Team Leader Choi's voice cracked like thunder.

"Get outside! Now!"

At that moment, the unknown old Hobgoblin turned its head.

Clink.

Its staff shook lightly.

—Mita. Allo.

The air shuddered.

Magic was taking form.

"Behind the shields!"

The tanks hurriedly raised their tower shields.

But that was the wrong call.

It hadn't cast an attack spell.

Boom. Boom. Boom!

"It's behind us! The passage is being blocked!"

"Run! Hurry!"

Damn it. Too late.

As if the clock had been turned back, the shattered stone gate stood intact again.

And it didn't stop there.

The rubble on the floor rose into two, then three layers of walls, and vines from the cave walls wrapped around them, binding them tight.

"Everyone, out of the way!"

It was Im Kkeokjeong. His muscles had swollen like they were about to burst—probably a Strength Enhancement Skill. Tower shield in hand, he charged the stone gate.

"Haaah!"

Bang! Crack!

"…Goddamn it."

Im Kkeokjeong dropped his heavily cracked tower shield, his face blank with disbelief. An E-rank Hunter had used a Skill and still failed to break through. All he had managed to do was wreck his shield.

Enhancement magic?

Whatever it was, one thing was certain.

An old Hobgoblin capable of magic this powerful had to be at least one or two tiers above the monsters we had faced so far.

And…

Whoosh!

There was someone among us who could fight it.

When did he—?

Team Leader Choi was already rushing toward the creature, as if he'd known from the start that we wouldn't be able to reopen the passage.

"The wind takes hold. Haste."

His body slid forward. More than a hundred meters[171] vanished in an instant. With five paces left, the sword came free from Team Leader Choi's waist.

Whoosh!

A full-power attack from a C-rank Hunter.

But the old Hobgoblin merely gave him a sinister grin.

—Karruk. Chwi. Akto.

The change happened in an instant.

Whoosh—

The hundred-odd corpses scattered across the altar shriveled, then dispersed like sand. The black energy, fully pulled out of them, gathered into one mass and smashed into Team Leader Choi's side.

Thud!

"Ghk."

Team Leader Choi bounced back fast. With a twisted face, he said,

[171] 100 meters is about 328 ft.

“We have to stop it. Right now.”

“…That thing?”

It was already too late.

Only a few seconds ago, it had been nothing more than energy given form. Now it was rapidly taking shape.

A hulking body nearly three meters[172] tall. Muscles swollen to the point of bursting. A monster wielding an enormous greatsword.

“What the hell is that…?”

Someone muttered in a daze. Like me, they had clearly never seen anything like it.

Only Team Leader Choi knew what the creatures were.

“A Hobgoblin Great Warrior. A C-rank Rare Monster.”

The fact that something so huge was a Hobgoblin was shocking enough, but it was nothing compared to what came next.

A C-rank Rare Monster?

Fuck, why is that thing showing up here?

Rare Monsters were creatures that appeared only infrequently within a given Gate. And since that Great Warrior was C-rank, it was something neither I nor the other team members should ever have encountered in our lives.

…Of course, not anymore.

“You want us to fight that thing?”

“Those things.”

Team Leader Choi pointed at the old Hobgoblin.

“A Hobgoblin Priest. Also a C-rank Rare Monster.”

“Ah, fuck…”

The curse slipped out before I could stop it. Im Kkeokjeong asked, his face rigid,

“What are our chances? Give it to me straight.”

“If we take out the Priest first, we have a chance. But to do that…”

Boom. Boom.

Team Leader Choi trailed off.

The Great Warrior was coming toward us.

One step. Then another.

The cave floor shook.

“We need to hold that thing back for a little while.”

Who?

“Us?”

“No. All of you.”

“Kuwooooh!”

[172] 3 meters is about 9.8 ft.

The Great Warrior’s roar sent a stalactite dropping from the cave ceiling.
Team Leader Choi turned with a resolute look I’d never seen on him before.
“The wind takes hold. Haste.”
Hey, you bastard.

Chapter 44

"Just hold out for five minutes."

With that, Team Leader Choi shot off like the wind. For better or worse, the Hobgoblin Great Warrior didn't give him so much as a glance.

"He's coming this way."

At my words, everyone nodded blankly.

"He is."

Boom, boom, boom!

"He's running this way."

"Defensive formation—!"

The team snapped into formation. I gripped my spear and moved as ordered. Between the tanks and the ranged dealers. Dead center—that was my spot.

No, for fuck's sake. I'm a porter…

Even if my life was going to go sideways, did it have to go this sideways?

They say an unlucky bastard can fall over backward and still break his nose. For 300,000 won,[173] I'd run into two mid-grade Rare Monsters. This wasn't just a broken nose. This was a broken nose and a cracked skull.

—Kuwaaaaah!

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior charged with a roar. Nearly three meters[174] of muscle and green hide—overwhelming all by itself.

Why is that greatsword so damn huge?

The thought of that thing swinging at me made me swallow hard.

"Can we stop it?"

"We'll have to try."

Im Kkeokjeong planted his tower shield in the ground and shouted.

"Archers! Don't hold back on mana! Pour it on!"

Swish, swish, swish!

Mana-charged arrows shot straight at the Great Warrior. They had enough force to punch through most shields, but…

Thunk, thunk.

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior gave its greatsword a casual swing and chopped every one of them in half. Even if they'd hit, I doubted they could have pierced that thick hide.

"Aim for the vitals! Keep shooting and slow it down!"

---

[173] 300,000 Korean won is about $210 or €190 at the project rates.

[174] Nearly three meters is nearly 9.8 ft.

Then the Great Warrior's eyes burned red. Once it drew up its magical power, its strength and speed were on a whole different level.

"Kuwooooooh!"

With a booming roar, the green giant leaped into the air.

Im Kkeokjeong screamed.

"Scatter!"

Before anyone had time to think, we threw ourselves aside.

Boom!

The greatsword smashed the ground to pieces. A blast of air sent dust whipping around us like a tornado.

"Ghh."

"Cough, cough."

Groans and coughing broke out beyond the curtain of dust. I crouched as low as I could and thought,

What kind of monster is that?

It couldn't compare to *that guy* from two years ago, but a chill still ran down my spine. In a fight like this, an F-rank Hunter like me was nothing but baggage.

I have to get as far away as I can while I have the chance.

Everything was lost in the haze. Nobody could tell friend from foe. This was my opening.

I stayed low and moved slowly, spear in one hand while the other felt through empty air.

Then—

Tap.

My fingertips hit something solid. Very hard, and wet.

It had to be the cave wall.

Already?

I'd thought I was farther away, but I must have been closer than I expected.

Fine by me. If I followed the wall, I could—

Squish.

"…?"

What was this now? I carefully probed the unpleasantly squishy thing.

There's fur, too. A person?

Maybe it was the head of someone who'd passed out. I held my breath and whispered,

"Kkeokjeong hyung?[175]"

No answer.

[175] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

“Who is it?”

This time, I got a reply.

Right above me.

“Grrr.”

A gust of wind swept through from somewhere and cleared the dust. I slowly looked up and saw a pair of gleaming red eyes.

“Grrk.”

“…”

I looked back down. Between thighs as thick as pillars and hard as stone, my dainty little hand was clamped around something.

I groaned under my breath.

“Ah, fuck…”

It was male instinct. Unbearable nausea. Disgust at myself. The next moment, my fingers loosened of their own accord.

Slide.

My limp hand slid down as the greatsword rose with force.

“Grrk.”

“I let go! I let go, so why are you doing this?!”

“Kuwoooooooh!”

Goddammit.

I wrung out every last bit of strength I had and ran.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior had completely lost it. It chased me like a lunatic, hacking in every direction with its greatsword.

Whoosh—

“Aaaaah!”

That one was actually close. I ducked at the last second, and the greatsword skimmed over my head and wrecked the cave wall.

“Taekyung!”

“Shoot!”

The team poured on arrows and throwing weapons, but…

“Kuwaaaaargh!”

It wasn’t enough to pull the Great Warrior’s attention. Its eyes had already rolled back.

I rolled, then rolled again, and cursed my luck.

I should’ve just popped it.

Instinct had beaten reason. A man's need to get his hand off *that* even one second sooner.

Whoosh!

The greatsword barely missed. It had been one close call after another, yet I still hadn't let the C-rank Rare Monster land a single clean hit.

Maybe it's because I've seen so much hell in Murim.

It sounded insane, but it was true. I could see its attacks. Moving half a beat ahead was what kept me alive.

Boom!

Of course, one hit from that thing and I'd be a goner.

"Taekyung, this way!"

I turned toward the voice. The team was waiting there in a defensive formation again.

"Fall back!"

Im Kkeokjeong charged the Great Warrior chasing me. Blue mana sheathed the tower shield, packed with enough force to smash most low-grade monsters to pieces.

"Hah!"

With a short shout, Im Kkeokjeong brushed past me. And then—

Crunch. Thud.

Something broke, and he shot backward at a vicious speed.

He flew a good ten meters,[176] slammed into the wall, and vomited a gush of blood.

"Gweeehk."

"…"

Was this for real?

I was stunned. The rest of the team, on the other hand, looked grimly determined.

"No! Kkeokjeong hyung![177]"

"We'll buy time! Take hyung[178] and get out!"

Then the greatsword sent another tank flying, tower shield and all.

Boom!

"Agh!"

"Jongmin!"

"We'll buy time! Take Jongmin and hyung[179] and get out!"

Thud!

"Aaargh!"

---

[176] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

[177] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

[178] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

[179] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

“Seokho!”

“…”

Smack!

That was the sound of the team being wiped out. The last member had charged in with a dagger, taken a knuckle to the skull, and gone flying. He twitched, then passed out.

At least they were all still breathing. Small mercies.

—Grrr…

Scratch that.

I kept my eyes on the monster and shouted,

“Team Leader!”

A fierce battle was still raging at the altar in the distance.

A tired voice came through the explosions.

“What?!”

“Are you still not done? It feels like it’s been more than five minutes!”

Boom! Boom! Fwoosh!

Lightning struck, and flames surged. Team Leader Choi screamed,

“Three more minutes!”

Anyone who didn’t know better might have taken him for a soccer referee. His bold call for extra time left me speechless.

—Karruk, karruk.

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior came toward me slowly. A cruel smile hung on its wide-split mouth. I eased back in time with its steps.

“That’s right. Come on. Come on.”

No choice. Same as before: run like hell and stall.

—Grrk.

But the Great Warrior didn’t play along.

“Huh?”

Its bulging eyes rolled toward the teammates sprawled unconscious on the ground. I had a very bad feeling about this.

“Don’t tell me…”

That was exactly it.

My heart dropped as I watched its back heading for Im Kkeokjeong.

“Hey! Hey, you!”

It ignored me completely.

Now I was the one in a panic.

If I leave it like this, they’re all dead.

I had to get its attention somehow. I grabbed one of the rocks scattered around me and threw it at the monster's head.

Thwack!

Direct hit.

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior turned and glared at me.

"Yeah. Come here."

—Grrr.

Its narrowed eyes flicked between me and Im Kkeokjeong. Then it started running at Im Kkeokjeong.

Boom, boom, boom!

"You crazy bastard!"

At this rate, Im Kkeokjeong and the rest of the team would all be wiped out. I was the only one who could stop it.

Stop that thing? Me?

A one-on-one fight against a C-rank Rare Monster.

A fight I could never win. But…

Ah, fuck.

I was already charging at it. Sometimes you had to fight even when you had no chance.

This was one of those times.

"You son of a bitch!"

Whoosh—!

The instant I thrust my spear at its broad back—

—Kururuk.

The green giant turned like it had been waiting for me. A smug smile curled its lips. The greatsword swept horizontally, shooting toward my side like a streak of light.

That's what you were after.

My mind went white. Could I even block that? Had I made the wrong call out of some pathetic sense of guilt and heroism?

But the die was already cast.

I have to hold.

There are times you have to fight with your life on the line. This was one of them.

Please!

I clenched my teeth and wrenched the iron spear around to intercept it. At the same time, the greatsword smashed into the shaft.

Rrrrk—

A roar of impact. Then enormous pressure. The greatsword cleaved straight through the iron spear and my waist—

"…Huh?"

The iron spear was fine. So was my waist. All that had happened was my feet had been pushed back a little.

A very, very little.

"…?"

What was this?

—G-Grrk?

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior's face flushed bright red. It pulled the greatsword back and hammered the iron spear again. Even through the confusion, I tightened my grip and blocked.

Boom!

My body slid back.

Maybe thirty centimeters?[180]

"…Huh."

—…Grrk.

The Hobgoblin Great Warrior's eyes met mine in the air between us. I'd been through this somewhere before.

That's right. The duel with Lee Seogeun. It was exactly like this.

I'd freaked out at his Level and thought I was dead, only to find out he was a total pushover. How was I supposed to forget a moment that absurd?

But I had the System backing me there.

This was reality. I was an F-rank Hunter with nothing. No System, not a damn thing.

How is this even…

Ding.

"Huh?"

I froze. For that instant, I couldn't see or hear a thing.

This can't be. This is actually insane.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Synchronization complete.
All systems are inherited.

And yet, it actually happened.

[180]Thirty centimeters is about 12 in.

“Ha… hahaha.”

A laugh slipped out of me like I’d lost my mind. The Hobgoblin Great Warrior stared at me like I was the crazy one.

Right. So that was how it was.

“I don’t know what the hell just happened…”

I grinned at the monster.

“But you’re fucking dead.”

Gurgle.

A wrinkled hand clutched at a throat. But the old goblin had neither the strength to stop the blood pouring out like a waterfall nor the time to spit out the spell still sitting on the tip of its tongue.

“What a nuisance.”

With that from Team Leader Choi, the light went out of the Hobgoblin Priest’s eyes.

I’m tired.

But he turned around at once. He still had work to do. Who knew how brutal a fight it would take to bring down another C-rank Rare Monster—

Slash—

“Kwaaaaargh!”

Team Leader Choi thought he was seeing things. That same Hobgoblin Great Warrior was screaming. With one arm severed, it staggered backward.

Who did that?

He watched the fight, forgetting that he was supposed to help. Ghostlike movement. A spearhead flowing like water as it carved the green giant to pieces.

Wait. A spear?

Of everyone here today, only one person used a spear.

The porter—no, Jin Taekyung?

That was him.

The F-rank Hunter who’d been hauling a backpack and skinning hides!

“What on earth…”

Team Leader Choi’s mouth slowly fell open.

“What’s going on?”

Chapter 45

Slash.

The red eyes blinked, almost docile. So even a C-rank Rare Monster—the terrifying Hobgoblin Great Warrior—could make a face like that.

Why hadn't I noticed before?

With that passing thought, I shook the blood from my spearhead. At the same moment—

Thud.

Something heavy hit the ground. The Great Warrior saw what it was and instinctively shuffled backward.

Well, fair enough. Its right arm had been severed cleanly below the elbow.

I thought you'd be a little different.

The Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique. Yeah, I'd used it to slip inside the creature's reach. The Great Warrior reflexively swung its right arm, but there was nothing left to swing.

"Forgot already?"

I pressed the spearhead against the Great Warrior's side and ripped it upward. The blade, charged with internal energy, split its tough hide and muscle.

Slash—

Its left arm fell away in a spray of green blood.

Both arms gone in an instant, the Hobgoblin Great Warrior let out a roar of rage and pain.

—Kuwaaaaaargh!

But I couldn't let my guard down. Even without arms, it was still more than dangerous enough with its body alone.

"Yeah. Come at me."

Before I'd even finished speaking, its massive frame charged.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

As expected, this thing's entire body was a weapon. Like the monster it was, it possessed primal senses and strength that far surpassed a human's.

Swish. Slash.

A hooked claw grazed my forearm. A chunk of flesh tore away, and blood poured out. Without flinching, I blocked the heel descending toward the crown of my head.

Thud. Crunch.

The ground beneath my feet began to sink.

Incredible strength. At this rate, I might be buried standing up.

If I didn't have internal energy, that is.

I drew up every last bit of internal energy in my dantian. Power flooded through every limb. As my spear shaft slowly rose, the Great Warrior's eyes wavered.

Too late.

It might have been different if the creature had been whole, but after losing both arms, the Hobgoblin Great Warrior was no longer a match for me.

—Grrr.

In the end, it was the first to back off. By then, the fight was as good as over.

I pressed forward and thrust my spear.

Jin Family's Spear Technique. First form.

The movements engraved into my body and mind unfolded in rapid succession.

Thrust. Cut. Block and strike with the shaft. Simple on their own, but the order and the angles made countless combinations.

That was my definition of martial arts.

Clang! Clang!

Swish. Swish-swish-swish!

Second form. Third form. Fourth…

The hooked claws, once as hard as steel, were sliced away. With every step the creature retreated, another wound opened and more blood spilled.

Before long, the Hobgoblin Great Warrior's back struck the wall.

"Grrrk…"

A C-rank Rare Monster. A creature that had once seemed impossible to fight. But the will to resist had long since vanished from its red eyes.

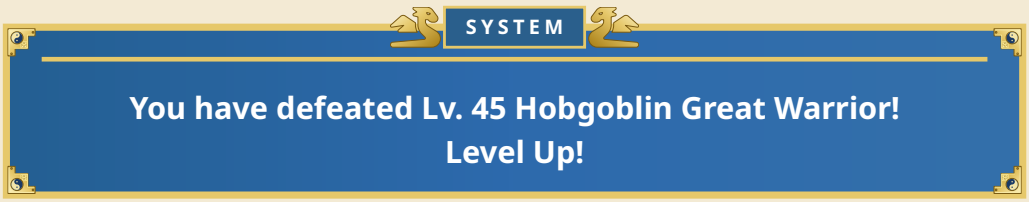
"Time to go."

Shunk.

Ghk. With a final death rattle, the hulking green body slid down the wall.

And then—

Ding.



The System notification rang out. I'd thought I would never hear or see one again…

The System, out of nowhere?

But I wasn't the only one confused.

"…Mr. Jin Taekyung?"

Team Leader Choi had already dealt with the Priest. His pupils shook as if an earthquake had struck while he looked back and forth between me and the Great Warrior's corpse.

"What… are you?"

Good question. I wanted to know too.

Heh heh. Heh heh heh.

"A Rare Monster?"

The cigarette dropped from the government official's mouth.

He looked like a born civil servant, so this couldn't have been welcome news. Sure enough, his gaze darted anxiously over us.

"W-what rank?"

Team Leader Choi wearily shook the Priest's staff.

Clank.

"C-rank Rare. Hobgoblin Priest."

"C-rank?! For fuck's—"

Hey, save the swearing. There's one more.

I kicked the Hobgoblin Great Warrior's greatsword, which I'd been using as a walking stick. The official turned at the dull clang.

"And that?"

"Buy one, get one more. C-rank Rare. Hobgoblin Great Warrior."

"Two mid-grade Rare Monsters? In an E-rank Gate?"

I got the reaction. This had to at least make some kind of sense.

The official spent a while looking back and forth between us and the equipment before finally nodding with a miserable expression.

"I'll contact my superiors first."

"Hey, mister. Hold on."

Im Kkeokjeong had regained consciousness at some point. I was supporting him, and he'd suffered severe injuries, including at least five broken bones.

"Call a healer. A pretty unnie.[181]"

The E-rank trio dropped onto the ground as well.

"And potions! Potions! Give us the good stuff!"

"For fuck's sake, how did you people even manage this Gate?!"

"All our gear's smashed too! Huh? What are you going to do about this?!"

[181] *Unnie* is a Korean term for an older sister or an older woman addressed familiarly by a woman. It can also be used playfully, as Kkeokjeong uses it here.

What did they think he was going to do? The government would compensate them for everything.

There was an actual law requiring it to cover every item consumed inside the Gate, along with medical expenses and compensation.

In other words, this was all a show to squeeze out a little more.

Tsk, tsk. Even so, people are watching.

That was when I felt a piercing stare from beside me.

"…Mr. Taekyung."

It was Team Leader Choi.

"What are you doing?"

He stared at me in confusion. More precisely, at the hand holding my dagger.

Grrrk.

The dagger, charged with internal energy, carved long gashes through my seven-year-old leather armor until it was too badly damaged to use.

"…"

"…"

"Team Leader Choi."

I heaved a sigh deep enough to sink the ground.

"That Hobgoblin Great Warrior was incredibly strong. I escaped with my life, but every piece of equipment I owned was destroyed."

"…"

"The armor that protected me for seven years. Now even my spear…"

"The spear looks perfectly—"

At that moment, I planted one foot on the middle of the spear and slowly pressed down.

Before the majesty of my three-digit Strength stat, the iron spear bent like taffy.

"Looks perfectly fine? This?"

"…"

Team Leader Choi shut his mouth.

Team Leader Choi was called away by the officials dispatched to take charge, and the other four were moved to an ambulance for treatment.

Instead of the musty break room, I was left alone in a spacious, comfortable office.

Now that the moment had finally arrived, my heart began to pound.

St-Status Window?

At that half-doubtful call, the System answered.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 33 Jin Taekyung
Job: First Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 0
Titles: 2 (Title effects active)
- Novice Trainee (Training speed +10%)
- Gambler (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one matches)

Strength: 120 **Stamina:** 125
Agility: 121 **Intelligence:** 20
Charm: 20 **Internal Energy:** 15 years
Remaining Points: 30
Synchronization is complete. Titles and Fame have changed.

“Fuck. It really appeared.”

I stared blankly at the Status Window for a moment before noticing something strange.

The Status Window… changed?

Two things jumped out first: my Fame had been reset to zero, and a Title was missing. The final line gave me a rough idea why.

Because this isn’t Murim?

All five hundred Fame I’d accumulated had been earned as a martial artist in Murim. The missing Title, *Scion of a Prestigious Family*, made sense for the same reason.

Well, I’m not the son of some prestigious family here. And I’m sure as hell no Hidden Dragon.

If I earned a Title here, it would probably be something like *Scion of the Common Folk*. Or *Earthworm* instead of *Hidden Dragon*.

“How much else changed?”

For about ten minutes I turned every System function on and off and tested them. The only thing that had changed was the Status Window.

No. There was one more.

The Quest Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Traitor
You have discovered the traitor's identity. Rejoin the main force, warn them of the traitor, and lead the battle to victory!
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Eliminate the traitor (Incomplete)
Win the battle (Incomplete)
Reward: Vast EXP and Fame
Valuable iron chest
Failure: Death

It was the Chain Quest I'd received after defeating Gwak Jun and the assassins. My thoughts grew tangled.

Does it want me to go back? To Murim?

I knew now. The Murim I'd experienced wasn't an illusion or a game. As wildly unrealistic as it sounded, Murim was probably…

Creak.

I turned at the sudden sound. Team Leader Choi stood in the doorway.

"Let's go, Mr. Taekyung."

It seemed the discussion had wrapped up. I put the thought aside and rose.

"The others…?"

"They should be on their way to the hospital by now. They'll need to stay there for about a week. You don't need to worry."

I wasn't particularly worried. Combat-type Hunters had sturdy bodies, and they'd received potions and healing magic. They would be back on their feet soon enough.

And…

"How did it go?"

"They'll contact us again within a few days. An investigator will probably visit you as well."

An investigator.

Not the sort of person I ever wanted to deal with again. But that wasn't the answer I wanted, so I asked once more.

"What about the other matter?"

"Hmm."

Team Leader Choi regarded me with a strange expression, like he was examining some fascinating animal.

Did he tell them the truth?

I didn't want my strength exposed. Especially not now, when I still had no idea why the System had appeared in reality or how any of this was connected to Murim.

An F-rank Hunter single-handedly killing a C-rank Rare Monster was unprecedented. A needle in a bag would eventually poke through, but I'd spent my whole life being the opposite of that—never standing out at all. I couldn't help being cautious.

So I had asked him:

"Could you keep what concerns me a secret?"

It must have been a difficult request from Team Leader Choi's perspective. I was asking him to give a false statement for someone he'd only just met.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Yes."

His grave voice made my heart sink.

Then he said, "Let's get something to eat."

"What?"

"Look."

Team Leader Choi held out his wrist. A gleaming Magic Gem digital watch showed two in the afternoon.

"It's an N Company model carved from a solid C-rank Magic Gem. It's enchanted with reinforcement magic, so in an emergency, you can even use it as a shield—"

So that's what he meant.

"…Let's go."

The man was impossible to read.

"Let's get some meat. Do you like Hanwoo?[182]"

"Hanwoo?"

"Yes. Highest grade."

And he was rich too.

"I never get to eat it."

This wasn't just any beef. It was Hanwoo. Top-grade Hanwoo, at that.

System or whatever—first, I needed to fill my empty stomach.

[182] Hanwoo is beef from Korean native cattle, prized as premium meat.

Chapter 46

Sizzle.

The meat hit the grill. Thick, red, and marbled with white streaks like snowflakes—it was the finest Hanwoo beef.

The shape, the sound, the smell. All of it was intoxicating. The only thing I didn't like was the price…

"Will this be enough? Let's order more after we eat. Some special cuts, too."

A rich C-rank Hunter was paying, so whatever.

How long had it been since I'd last had Hanwoo?

Food in Murim was spicy, salty, and bland. And even then, more days than not, I couldn't eat properly. For thirty days, my stomach had been abused with beef jerky, fasting pills, and rice balls.

Chomp. Chomp-chomp.

The best thing about beef was how quickly you could eat it. As soon as it looked more or less done, it went straight into my mouth.

Every chew felt like walking on clouds. This piece, that piece, that one too—every last one tasted like heaven.

"Hnnngh."

Team Leader Choi watched me with that peculiar look of his.

"Would you like some more?"

"No. I should hold back on overeating."

"We're on our twenty-fifth serving…"

"Twelve servings each isn't all that much."

"I've only eaten three."

"Oh, can we order some yukhoe?[183]"

"…Yes."

"Rice, too."

"…"

And so the storm of a meal finally came to an end. At last, Team Leader Choi spoke.

"I told them I killed both the Priest and the Great Warrior."

"Oh. Thank you."

"Don't mention it. Let's call it a fair deal. If anything, I have something to thank you for as well."

A fair deal.

[183] Yukhoe is seasoned Korean raw beef.

He wasn't wrong. I'd bought myself time to think, and he would gain a reputation. After all, he had led five low-rank Hunters and killed two mid-grade Rare Monsters.

The fact that no one had died in the process would be a huge boost to the Guild's publicity, too.

What if Synchronization hadn't restored my strength?

Who knew? Someone probably would have died. Maybe none of us would have made it out alive.

"You were already thinking along those lines."

He wasn't just some eccentric. Not with instincts that sharp.

I smiled awkwardly.

"It works out well for both of us."

"Good for both of us. Both of us…"

Team Leader Choi muttered to himself, then abruptly asked,

"Would you like to join the Guild?"

"Pffft!"

Team Leader Choi lifted the tablecloth and blocked the water, then smoothly produced a business card with practiced elegance.

> **Peace Guild, Team 1 Leader Choi Minwoo**

What the hell was this? For a second I was completely thrown.

"Y-you're making me a recruitment offer? Right now?"

"That's right. We're always looking for talent."

I took the card and found myself strangely moved.

It seemed like only yesterday that I'd been bowing like a shrimp at job interviews…

Live long enough and you really do see everything.

An actual recruitment offer—and he was even treating me like talent. F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung, you'd come a long way.

"Our Guild is still new, and we don't have many members, but we're excellent where it counts. For example…"

Team Leader Choi elegantly swirled his wineglass. When had he even ordered that?

"Our finances are extremely solid."

"Ooh, finances!"

"Which means our employee benefits are excellent."

"Ooh, benefits backed by solid finances!"

"Our Guild Master is a B-rank Hunter."

"Ooh, a high-ranking Hunter—the source of those solid finances!"

"And there's no need to worry about restructuring."

"Ooh, job security!"

Team Leader Choi asked with an affluent smile,

"Will you join us?"

I scratched my head.

"No. That's a little…"

"…Pardon?"

"I have circumstances that make it difficult at the moment. I need some time."

If I followed my heart, I'd sign the contract right away—signature, seal, thumbprint, even a kiss mark.

But what if the System disappears tomorrow?

I'd be dead broke.

Overnight, I'd go from being called talent to being called a human disaster.[184]

"Is it a money problem?"

Money was always a problem.

But this was more important. I couldn't let the wad of cash dangling in front of me blind me into making a snap decision.

"It's difficult to explain. I'm sorry, but this isn't something I can decide right now…"

"One hundred million won.[185]"

"A hundred million?"

"Just the signing bonus. The rest will match the minimum terms for a C-rank Hunter."

That was dangerous. This time, it was really dangerous.

But I resisted with superhuman patience. Hadn't I learned long ago that life was never that easy?

That money might come back to choke me.

"I'm sorry."

Team Leader Choi looked at me quietly, then nodded.

"I'll wait to hear from you."

One person left, and one remained.

Team Leader Choi—no, Choi Minwoo—silently stared at the seat Jin Taekyung had vacated, then took out his phone.

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[184] In Korean, *injae* can mean "talent" (□□) or "human disaster" (□□), depending on the characters.

[185] One hundred million won is about $71,000 or €65,000.

Beep. Beep. Click.

“—You bastard, are you psychic? I was just about to call you.”

“How did that thing I asked about turn out?”

“—I looked into it because you asked, but… is there something about this Jin Taekyung guy?”

“That’s what I called you to find out. So? What did you learn?”

“—It’s a dime-a-dozen case. Awakened at twenty, seven years ago, and assessed as F-rank. There’s a record of him graduating at the top of his class from the Hunter training center…”

Jin Taekyung’s past seven years spilled from the other end of the phone. Then, at one point, Choi Minwoo’s eyebrows twitched.

“What? The Sangdong Station Mutated Gate?”

“—Yeah. You know about that incident, right?”

How could he not? It had happened only two years ago, so Choi Minwoo remembered it clearly.

“—He was the only survivor. I checked that part myself, and it surprised me, too.”

Choi Minwoo tipped his glass of water. Thinking he’d grabbed a lead on how an F-rank Hunter had killed a mid-grade Rare Monster alone made his throat burn.

“And?”

“—He took six months off. The Hunter Administration kept sending investigators, and I guess he spent the time trying to pull himself together. You know how serious the incident was.”

“And then?”

“—That’s it. He went back to his Guild, ran Gates his ass off for a year and a half, then got fired. That was exactly three days ago.”

“Why was he fired?”

“—Technically, restructuring, but what kind of restructuring does a tiny little Guild like that need? The incident probably had a lot to do with it. They kept looking over their shoulders at the Administration, then finally pushed him out. He must’ve been uncomfortable for them to keep around.”

“That’s all?”

“—As far as I can tell. Want me to send you the file separately?”

“Send it now. I’m hanging up.”

“—Hey, hey!”

Click.

Choi Minwoo tapped his long fingers against the table.

Jin Taekyung. F-rank Hunter. The sole survivor of the Sangdong Station Mutated Gate.

And…

At least a C-rank Hunter.

That was the absolute minimum. The image of Taekyung driving a C-rank Rare Monster into a corner alone, with overwhelming strength and skill, kept flickering before his eyes.

And yet he's F-rank.

There were only two possibilities. Either he had been hiding his strength, or he had recently reawakened.

Choi Minwoo suspected the latter, but even that defied common sense.

Countless Hunters retired without ever rising a single rank.

A reawakening that took someone from F-rank to C-rank was, without question, extraordinarily rare.

This isn't some game. What the hell is he?

Choi Minwoo shook his head. He felt as if he'd been bewitched by a ghost.

I'll have to look into him some more.

As he rose from his seat, the restaurant owner approached and held out the bill.

"That will be 1,937,000 won.[186]"

"…"

Now he really felt as if he'd been bewitched by a ghost.

"Fuck. I'm screwed."

I dropped to the ground in the filthy recycling area. The one thing that should have been there was nowhere in sight.

"It's gone. It's gone. My capsule is gone."

I'd been anxious ever since parting ways with Team Leader Choi. But I hadn't expected someone to take it in less than half a day. I shouted into the empty air.

"Who the fuck took it?!"

And an answer came back.

"Me, you son of a bitch."

Jinho was smoking on the roof of the goshiwon[187] building, in the same spot where I'd seen him that morning. He exhaled a wistful stream of smoke and continued.

"I spent ten years crying, regretting it, and making vows…"

"You want me to make you cry and regret it for real?"

"You're no fun. You haven't seen this movie, have you?"

"Quit joking around. This is serious."

"What, did you come up empty today?"

---

[186] 1,937,000 won is about $1,400 or €1,200.

[187] A goshiwon is a building of small, inexpensive rooms for rent.

"No."

My voice drained of strength as I went on.

"The capsule."

"…Huh?"

"Some bastard took my capsule."

"Cough! Cough-cough!"

Maybe he'd inhaled the cigarette smoke wrong. Jinho hyung[188] coughed like a maniac before he finally managed to speak.

"D-didn't you throw it away because you didn't need it?"

"I did."

Until the System came back.

I hadn't expected the situation to change this much in just a few hours.

I should've kept it for one more day.

Where was I even supposed to start looking? I let out a deep sigh.

"Hyung,[189] you didn't happen to see who took it, did you?"

"Uh… well."

Jinho scratched his head.

"If I saw it, then I saw it. If I didn't, then I didn't."

Was that supposed to be an answer, or was it just crap?

When I glared at him, he smiled sheepishly.

"Look, it's not like I'm hoping for a finder's fee or anything…"

It definitely sounded like he wanted a finder's fee.

Anyway, that wasn't the point. I shot to my feet and asked,

"You saw them? You're sure?"

"If I had to choose, I'd say I did."

"Who? Where did they go?"

"I'm not asking for a finder's fee, but roughly how much were you thinking?"

"…One hundred thousand won?[190]"

"Oh, dear. Maybe I'm getting old. My memory's a little hazy."

"For fuck's sake."

"Right, then. Good luck in this heat."

"The finder's fee is one hundred and eighty thousand won.[191]"

Apparently satisfied with the amount, Jinho beamed.

"Your capsule. I picked it up."

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[188] Hyung is a term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[189] Hyung is a term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[190] One hundred thousand won is about $71 or €65.

[191] One hundred and eighty thousand won is about $130 or €120. The Korean for "eighteen," *sip-pal*, echoes the swear Taekyung just used; he also switches abruptly to polite speech.

"…?"

It took me exactly three seconds to understand.

What a goddamn daylight robber.

I was speechless. He'd really stabbed me in the back like this?

"But there wasn't anywhere suitable to put it. My room's too small, you know."

"So?"

"I put it back in your room. I did good, right?"

How could I hit this man so thoroughly that word would spread about what a fine job I'd done?

My fists trembled.

"It really is here."

The capsule occupied half the studio as if nothing had happened. All I could do was let out a hollow laugh.

Should I call this lucky?

Of all the people who could have taken it, it had been Jinho.

I opened the lid, picked up the user manual that had been tossed onto the worn seat, and flipped to the last page.

> **Main Features**
>
> - A customized capsule for one person! Once a user is registered, the capsule becomes permanently bound to that user and remains so until their death.

…Come on. No way.

It has to be a simple coincidence.

But I couldn't shake the unease. I glared at the capsule, the source of everything that had happened.

What the hell is this thing?

The reason I'd thrown the capsule into the recycling area that morning was so I could forget everything. My life was already dry enough; I wanted to write it off as one nightmare and keep living my life as I was.

But things were different now.

Because I have the System.

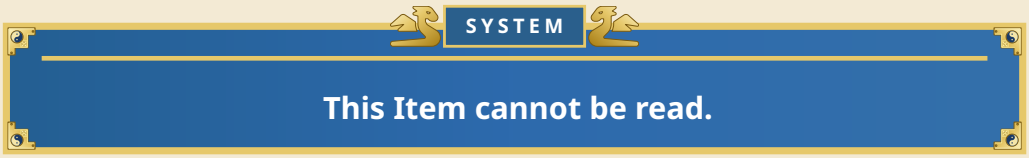
The System…

Then something occurred to me. I placed my hand on the capsule's surface and murmured,

"Item check."

Ding.

Just as I thought. The corners of my mouth had just begun to rise when—



"...It can't be read?"

That had never happened before.

Is it because I'm not in Murim?

Flustered, I started checking random objects around the room. The television, a ballpoint pen, even my pillow. Every time, the System displayed accurate information.

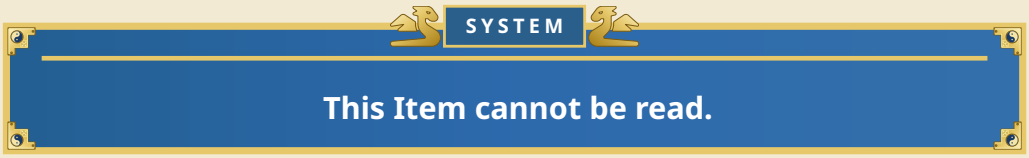
There was only one exception.

It couldn't read the capsule.

"Wow. This is driving me nuts."

Just in case, I picked up the user manual. The result was the same.

Ding.



I flopped onto the bed. I stared blankly at the old, yellow-stained ceiling and thought.

What's going on?

None of this made sense yet. But one thing was certain.

I've become stronger. Incomparably stronger.

Power had soaked into every fiber of my body. Internal energy writhed in my dantian.

Synchronization had given me strength. Strength far beyond that of an F-rank Hunter. Strength enough to defeat a C-rank Rare Monster alone.

Would you like to join the Guild?

It was the first recruitment offer I'd ever received. But I refused. When someone recognized me, fear had come before joy.

Can't blame me.

I'd endured seven years with the label of F-rank Hunter. I was a caterpillar that had spent its whole life crawling through the dirt, only to suddenly sprout wings called the System.

Of course I was afraid.

But what if I can keep using this power? What if I can keep using the System?

My heart pounded at the mere thought.

At the same time, the past seven years flashed through my mind. The name F-rank, stamped on me like a brand despite all the insane effort I'd put in. Even the memories from two years ago, when I'd trembled at other people's contempt, at the guilt and the helplessness.

"Fuck…"

I couldn't take it anymore. I shot to my feet, raced out of the goshiwon[192], and flagged down a passing taxi.

"Where would you like to go?"

I already knew my destination.

"Take me to the Bucheon Branch of the Hunter Association."

A Hunter rank reassessment.

F-rank Hunter. I'd start by breaking the loathsome shackle that had tormented me for so long.

Let's give it a shot.

As I clenched my fist, the taxi driver said,

"This is a Seoul taxi."

"Oh."

[192] A goshiwon is a building of small, inexpensive rooms for rent.

Chapter 47

The Hunter Association.

The name had first appeared some thirty years ago, when the Great Cataclysm ended.

The first-generation Hunters who survived that blood-soaked catastrophe raised their flag, and over the years, the Hunter Association grew into an organization of tremendous stature.

Gulp.

I swallowed as I stared up at the Association building towering before me. Its sheer size and height made it stand out even in this dense forest of skyscrapers. Though it was an ordinary weekday, countless people streamed in and out.

How many years has it been?

Every Awakened underwent rank measurement under the Association's supervision.

I was no different. Thinking of twenty-year-old Jin Taekyung walking in here with his heart full of excitement almost made me laugh—like hell it did.

Now that I'm actually here, I'm incredibly nervous.

I entered the lobby on stiff legs. The place was the size of a playing field and packed with people. Following the electronic signs posted throughout the lobby, I found the place I wanted.

Measurement Waiting Room

On the clerk's instructions, I filled out the paperwork and went inside. Dozens of people were waiting to be measured.

Thud.

The door shut, and everyone's eyes shot into me like arrows.

I can't breathe. This is suffocating.

Even the air was different here. A taut tension pressed down on the entire waiting room.

One measurement decides your whole Hunter life.

I was no exception. I'd once been so nervous that I farted in front of an examiner. That pretty much said it all.

I was waiting my turn, lost in thought, when—

"Jin Taekyung?"

A familiar voice came from behind me. I slowly turned my head.

There he was.

"I thought it might be you. Sure enough."

A potbellied, middle-aged man with a bulbous nose. A face I couldn't forget no matter how hard I tried.

…Team Leader Kim?

Kim Sangshik. A founding member and team leader of Sopung Guild, where I'd spent years. He could be summed up in one word.

Former boss.

"Wow, I never expected to run into you here. Good to see you."

Team Leader Kim thrust out his hand with a hearty laugh. I hesitated for a moment, then shook it.

"Likewise. It's been a while."

"What do you mean, a while? It's only been a few days."

"Those few days felt pretty long to me."

I'd said it thinking of Murim, but Team Leader Kim would take it another way. After all, he was the one who'd handed me my dismissal only a few days ago.

"It's because it's summer. My days have felt long lately too."

"Really?"

Watching him slip past the remark like a sly old fox, I let out a dry laugh.

He was always an amusing man.

In more ways than one.

"So what brings you here?"

"I had some business. What about you, Team Leader?"

"Came to scout. Heard there was a decent one this time."

They'd fired me for staff cuts in a restructuring. And he was here to scout.

"I see."

That was all I had to say. It was the same tired story everyone knew, and it was already over. I had no lingering attachment to it.

"What about you? Why are you here? Don't tell me you're trying to get reassessed."

"Yes."

Team Leader Kim smiled.

"Nice try, but isn't that a waste of money? A reassessment isn't cheap. Must be a burden for an F-rank Hunter."

"I thought I'd give it a try anyway. Just in case."

"You should save your money while you're young. What's going to change if you keep clinging to something that'll never work?"

"Who knows? I think this time might be different."

"It's not that easy—"

"Team Leader."

"Huh? What?"

I smiled gently.

"That's enough."

Team Leader Kim's smile cracked.

"What?"

"I said that's enough. I'm out of the Guild now, so stay out of my business."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

What did it mean?

"You know exactly what I mean."

"…"

"All that 'It couldn't be helped,' 'At least you survived,' and 'Forget about it and make a fresh start.' You pretended to comfort me while chipping away at me behind my back."

"You…"

"Weren't you the first one to tell the Guild Master to fire me? Did you think I wouldn't find out?"

Kim Sangshik was a half-baked, petty little man.

Short on both humanity and ability.

Even inside Gates, he was always too busy saving his own skin. His reputation within the Guild was rock-bottom.

"Who did you put in my place after firing me? How much did they pay you to get them in?"

"Hey, Jin Taekyung."

Team Leader Kim pressed down on my shoulder and growled. He might not look it, but he was one of only three D-rank Hunters in Sopung Guild. With that kind of strength, he could toy with an F-rank Hunter like me using one hand.

But—

"Take your hand off."

I didn't even blink. It wasn't only the System that had synchronized. My martial arts, my stats, and even my steel-like Muscles and Bones had come with it.

"I'll count to three. Take your hand off."

"You little bastard. I've been putting up with you, but—"

I didn't hesitate.

"One. Two."

Three.

The instant I seized Kim Sangshik's wrist—

Clack.

"Would the next group please come in? Numbers twenty-one through thirty!"

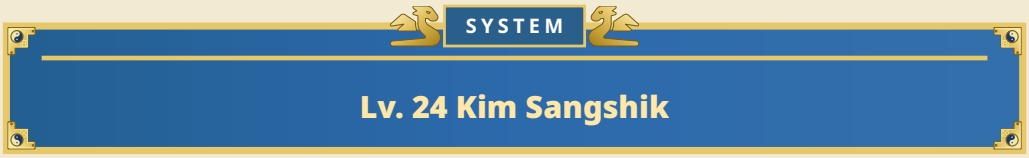
An Association examiner entered with a file in hand, and we sprang apart without waiting for the other to move first. Getting on the Association's bad side wouldn't do either of us any good.

"Consider yourself lucky."

"Who? Me, or you?"

Kim Sangshik's flushed face looked downright ridiculous.

So did the Level Window I picked up through Qi Sense.



"Meeting you was disgusting. Let's never see each other again."

I rose without a shred of regret. My waiting number was thirty.

My steps toward the examiner were no longer stiff.

"Number twenty-one. Please come forward."

A tense-looking Awakened stood before the measuring device. Made from an A-rank Magic Gem, it scanned his entire body and converted the mana inside him into numbers.

Bzzzzzt—

The examiner checked the reading.

"Amount of mana distributed throughout the body: F-rank."

The Awakened's face turned ashen. But it was too soon to despair. He still had a second chance.

"Try moving your mana. Concentrate as hard as you can and imagine firing it into the measuring device."

They were testing his mana control. Realizing it wasn't over yet, the Awakened gritted his teeth and strained with every ounce of strength he had—

Pfffft.

"…"

"…"

Looking ready to vomit, the examiner said, "Control ability: F-rank."

"Please! Just let me try one more time!"

"No. Next."

The line moved quickly.

Everyone was E-rank or F-rank. One guy wasn't even Awakened.

"This is a scam! A scam! That measuring device is made in China, isn't it? Huh? You bastards!"

"Handle him."

At the examiner's command, the security Hunters waiting nearby dragged the fraudster away. Even if that guy miraculously Awakened someday, he'd probably end up on the Association's blacklist.

"Next. Number thirty."

Here it came.

I took a deep breath and stepped forward. The examiner glanced at the file in his hand.

"This is a reassessment?"

"Yes."

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, you were rated F-rank seven years ago… You're aware that reassessments carry a separate fee, correct?"

From his tone, he might as well have been telling me not to waste my money and to go home while I still could.

The usual attitude toward an F-rank Hunter.

Do they think I'm a beggar?

I was used to it. That didn't make it any less insulting. When I glared at him, the examiner gave a short laugh.

"I'm only mentioning it in case you weren't aware, but the fee is two million won.[193]"

"…The price went up?"

"It has been a few years."

Fuck. I didn't know that.

How much was in my account right now…?

"Then we'll begin the measurement."

Nervous, I closed my eyes.

And the next moment—

Bzzzzzt.

A wave of magical power rolled out of the measuring device and swept through my whole body.

My fifteen years of internal energy responded with a shudder.

What rank will I get?

C-rank? No, I'd be happy with D-rank. But more than ten seconds passed, and the examiner still said nothing.

"Uh… Why is it doing this?"

[193] Two million Korean won is about $1,400 or €1,300.

"What's wrong?"

Flustered, he looked back and forth between the device and me, then cleared his throat.

"There seems to be some kind of error… We'll move on to the next step for now."

I had no idea what was happening, but strangely, it didn't feel ominous.

I've got a good feeling about this.

My heart pounding, I drew up my internal energy.

Ssshhh.

At the call of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, fifteen years of internal energy surged up and shot toward the measuring device.

At the lobby entrance—

"Well done."

Kim Sangshik patted a young man on the shoulder. As of today, the promising young man had officially been rated D-rank.

He would soon join Sopung Guild and be assigned to Kim Sangshik's team.

Thinking of the day to come, Kim Sangshik smiled proudly.

"Father and son on the same team. That's my boy."

"What are you talking about? I'm not even an official Hunter yet. I still have to go through the training center."

"Don't worry. Your father already took care of it."

"Wait, really? Didn't you say the Guild didn't have any openings?"

"There's always a way."

He didn't mention that he'd made room by firing the lowest-ranked Hunter, who had long been a thorn in his side.

"Anyway, get plenty of rest this week. Starting next week, we'll go to work together __"

Kim Sangshik's face suddenly twisted.

"What's wrong?"

"…Nothing. Go wait in the car."

Once his son had left, Kim Sangshik rolled up his shirtsleeve.

His wrist was already swollen blue-black. The sight made him grind his teeth.

"Jin Taekyung, you fucking bastard."

He'd disliked that bastard from the start. An F-rank Hunter had no business being deputy team leader, and he'd hated the way Taekyung acted like a brother to the former team leader, who was now dead.

That bastard should've fucking died with him back then.

The unfortunate accident two years ago had been a stroke of extraordinary luck for Kim Sangshik.

After being sidelined over several sex scandals, he'd returned triumphantly as team leader. A few days ago, he'd even managed to get Jin Taekyung thrown out.

But did that bastard really reawaken?

Kim Sangshik stared down at his throbbing wrist.

It had lasted only an instant, but the strength he'd felt had been tremendous. Taekyung might have reawakened as an E-rank—or perhaps even a D-rank.

"No. Reawakening isn't child's play."

Maybe he'd simply gotten weaker because he hadn't exercised lately. Kim Sangshik was muttering to himself, his thoughts in turmoil, when—

"Breaking news from the measurement room."

"Did someone promising show up?"

"They say a big fish surfaced. C-rank."

"C-rank? That's not bad, but is it really enough to call him a big fish?"

"His mana control is supposedly A-rank."

"What? A-rank? Get your hooks into him, now!"

"Yes, this is Choi Minsu from Sangdong Guild. The reason I'm calling is…"

A stir spread among the scouts prowling the lobby entrance like hyenas.

Most had been sent by small and midsized Guilds, but the handful representing major Guilds were already moving quickly.

C-rank alone is impressive, and he's gifted with mana control on top of it?

This was a jackpot.

Kim Sangshik's mind snapped into focus. He cast every thought of Jin Taekyung aside and pulled out his phone.

"Hey, Team Leader Kim. Did that business go well?"

The deep voice on the other end belonged to Sopung Guild's Guild Master.

Kim Sangshik spoke urgently.

"Guild Master, it's chaos here. A C-rank just appeared, and they say his mana control is on the level of a high-ranking Hunter."

"What? Where did a guy like that come from?"

"Exactly. The major Guilds always snatch them out from under us, but it looks like they were a step late this time."

"Good. So that's how it is…"

Huff. Huff.

Rough breathing came through the phone, as though the Guild Master were excited. Even the way he addressed Kim Sangshik changed.

“Sangshik. You hold on to that guy no matter what. Tell him we’ll meet any conditions he wants.”

“How high can we go?”

“Don’t worry about the money. Add plenty on top of whatever the others offer. The major Guilds will back off if they decide he isn’t profitable enough. It’s not like they’re desperate for him.”

“Yes, yes.”

“I’m on my way. Keep him there until I arrive. If you pull this off… you know what that means, right?”

After ending the call, Kim Sangshik clenched his fist.

We’ve got this!

He was an old hand at this business. Holding on to a newly Awakened rookie would be easy.

This was a world where money could put even ghosts to work.

Double whatever everyone else offers. I’ll offer him twice as much, no matter what.

The commotion grew louder. The elevator was descending from the third floor, where the measurement room was located.

“He’s coming!”

“Hey, stop shoving!”

Some twenty scouts crowded around the elevator doors like a swarm of ants. Kim Sangshik muscled his way to the front and readied his business card.

Ding.

At last, the elevator doors opened.

Kim Sangshik bowed low and launched into his prepared speech.

“Hello. I’m Team Leader Kim Sangshik of Sopung Guild. We are a prestigious Guild with a long tradition here in Bucheon—”

“That’s the first time I’ve ever heard anyone call Sopung a prestigious Guild.”

“…What?”

At the familiar voice, Kim Sangshik slowly raised his head.

Their eyes met.

At the same time, Kim Sangshik’s buttonhole-sized eyes went wide.

“Y-you…”

Jin Taekyung grinned.

“We meet again, Mr. Kim Sangshik.”

Chapter 48

"Y-you? What are you doing here?"

"Good question. What am I doing here?"

"Then, could it be…?"

"What do you mean, 'could it be'? It is."

Kim Sangshik's face turned dark and sallow, like a man suffering from shit poisoning.

Seeing him like that felt like finally passing ten years' worth of constipation. Ah, so this was a shitgasm.

"Anyway, let's take a step back. We're not the only ones here, you know."

I stepped forward, and Kim Sangshik retreated weakly.

The other scouts surrounded me, business cards in hand.

"We're from Sangdong Guild. We promise you the best possible treatment."

"Instead of doing this here, why don't we move somewhere private and talk…"

Recruitment offers poured in from every direction. Within moments, I had dozens of business cards in my hands.

So this is what it feels like.

It felt strange. Surreal. Things I hadn't experienced once in seven years were unfolding right before my eyes.

In just half a day, the world around me had changed.

No.

I'm the one who changed.

People said C-rank was where you started being a real Hunter in this business. Exceptional abilities, a high salary, and recognition from society as a mid-level Hunter.

It finally sank in that I had set foot on that path.

And…

This was only the beginning.

With the System's power, I could keep growing.

That was how I would step onto a new path faster than any other Hunter.

"Sir, name your terms and we'll meet them, no matter what."

"Ah, sure. I'll contact you later."

"You mean it, right? We'll be waiting!"

No. Don't wait. I'm not going to call.

"All right, everyone, calm down."

Association security guards stepped in to hold back the scouts who refused to leave me alone.

They normally wouldn't go this far for a C-rank Hunter, but my case was so unusual that it seemed to be attracting a lot of attention.

Well, I did jump all the way to C-rank from a single reawakening.

It wasn't a bad feeling. No—it felt good.

Suppressing the smile that kept tugging at my lips, I left the Association. Even then, one person followed me out.

"Jin Taekyung! No, Mr. Taekyung!"

"Heh."

I looked at Kim Sangshik and swallowed a hollow laugh.

Only thirty minutes ago, he'd been calling me a bastard. Now I was suddenly *Mr. Taekyung*.

"What do you want?"

"I'm sorry about earlier. Really. And I'm sorry about everything that happened before, too."

Kim Sangshik rambled on, confessing every wrong he'd ever done me. Once his untimely confession was over, he finally got to the point.

"So let's forget all that and treat this as business."

"Business."

I rolled the word around on my tongue.

It sounded nice. It felt awful. All the more so because the business partner in question was Kim Sangshik and Sopung Guild.

"You know how it is, Mr. Taekyung. Unless you're dealing with a major Guild, they're all more or less the same."

"I know. I also know that even the major Guilds will reach out to a C-rank Hunter."

"I'm telling you to think carefully. They're not desperate. Major Guilds can find C-rank Hunters without much trouble, so they'll treat you accordingly."

Kim Sangshik kept going, spraying spit as he talked.

"No matter how much anyone else offers, we'll top it. The Guild Master has already approved it, so you can count on that."

Sopung Guild had been in steady decline for several years.

Given the situation, the Guild Master seemed scared shitless.

And this guy's no different.

His standing in the Guild was already at rock bottom, and now the F-rank Hunter he'd fired on a whim a few days ago had reawakened as a C-rank.

The corners of my mouth rose at the thought of what would happen once the Guild Master, a man notorious for his temper, found out.

"Just look at it positively. Actually, forget standing around here. Why don't we go somewhere decent and talk it out honestly? The Guild Master is on his way here right—"

“Mr. Kim Sangshik.”

At my quiet voice, Sangshik fell silent.

“If you want to recruit me, tell the Guild Master this. Don’t leave out a single word.”

“Tell him what?”

“I’ll think about it if he gets rid of one man I can’t stand the sight of.”

It was obvious who I meant.

Leaving Kim Sangshik behind with his face twisted in fury, I got into a taxi.

Yeah. That should do it.

I sank deep into the soft seat.

The rank reassessment. Running into old bad blood. An indescribable rush, and at the same time a sense of relief.

“Where would you like to go?”

“Hope Goshiwon[194] at Songnae Station.”

The taxi driver looked at me and chuckled.

“Oh, you’re that passenger from earlier.”

“Ah.”

Goddamn Seoul taxis.

“What’s gotten into you? You actually bought beef.”

We spread out a mat and set up a grill on the goshiwon[195] roof. Jinho hyung[196] gazed contentedly at the meat as it cooked.

“All right. In recognition of your sincerity, I’ll forget about the finder’s fee.”

“I wasn’t planning to pay you anyway.”

“Are you some kind of thug?”

“Right back at you.”

We sat across from each other, sipping soju.[197]

“But where did you get the money? Just this month, you were whining about how hard up you were.”

“Today’s pay.”

“How much could that possibly be? Did getting fired from the Guild make you give up on life?”

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[194] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rooms, often rented by students or people on tight budgets.

[195] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rooms, often rented by students or people on tight budgets.

[196] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[197] *Soju* is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

"How much?"

I couldn't help letting out a little laugh.

"Oh, now you're laughing?"

"Of course I am. You're treating ten million won[198] like pocket change."

Jinho froze.

"How much?"

"Ten million won."[199]

"You made ten million won[200] from one day's work?"

"A little more came in, but that's for now."

"You didn't…"

Jinho swallowed hard. He caught on fast. I gave him a meaningful smile.

"That's right. Today, I—"

"Did you sell an organ?"

Should I kill him?

I let out a long sigh, then downed my drink.

"Tell me the truth. As the goshiwon[201] manager, I have a duty to know."

If you only heard that, you'd think he was the prime minister, not a goshiwon[202] manager.

"I earned it at a Gate."

"Show me proof. I only believe what I see with my own eyes."

"Suit yourself. Here."

I handed him my phone. The message had arrived while I was on my way back from the Association after the reassessment.

The sender was…

"Designer-Brand Junkie? Who's this?"

"The Team Leader I ran the raid with today."

"He must be rich. I want to become sworn brothers with him."

This guy and I really did think alike.

A moment later, Jinho's eyes widened as he read the message.

"Ten million three hundred thousand won?[203] Am I reading this right?"

"Probably."

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[198] Ten million won is about $7,100 or €6,500.

[199] Ten million won is about $7,100 or €6,500.

[200] Ten million won is about $7,100 or €6,500.

[201] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rooms, often rented by students or people on tight budgets.

[202] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rooms, often rented by students or people on tight budgets.

[203] Ten million three hundred thousand won is about $7,400 or €6,600.

According to the contract, I was supposed to receive three hundred thousand won.[204] Team Leader Choi had added another ten million.[205]

And there's still a balance left.

The Hobgoblin Priest and Hobgoblin Great Warrior were C-rank Rare Monsters. Team Leader Choi had added that he was looking for buyers for their equipment, hides, and Magic Gems.

> "We'll make an additional payment as soon as they're sold."

The next thing I knew, I was at a nearby supermarket, sweeping up every piece of beef I could get my hands on.

"You…"

Jinho stared blankly between me and the phone in his hand.

"Where the hell have you been, and what did you do?"

"It's a long story."

Jinho hyung[206] chuckled and gripped the scissors.

"The story's long, but your life's about to be short?"

Where was I even supposed to begin?

I had decided not to tell him anything more about the capsule.

It seemed better to let him keep believing it was an absurd lie.

"Two Rare Monsters showed up at the Gate today, and…"

At a life-or-death moment, the luck of a reawakening had come, and I'd been able to take them down. Then I told him about the Association.

It was a hastily stitched-together story, but Jinho bought it.

"So you're a C-rank Hunter now?"

"The reassessment process takes a few days, so technically, not yet."

"Same thing, you idiot."

His face was dazed and his voice hoarse.

Jinho hyung[207] stared at me for a long moment. Moisture gathered in his eyes.

What's gotten into this guy?

"…Don't tell me you're crying?"

"The fuck I am. What kind of bullshit is that?"

He turned away with an unnecessary curse, but he couldn't hide the single tear that slipped down. I watched him out of the corner of my eye as he roughly rubbed his face with his sleeve.

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[204] Three hundred thousand won is about $210 or €190.

[205] Ten million won is about $7,100 or €6,500.

[206] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[207] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

"Hyung?"[208]

"Turn the meat over. It's burning."

"Don't change the subject."

"I said it's burning!"

"Okay, okay."

Sizzle.

As I turned the meat, I felt flustered, yet something tickled deep in my chest.

Come to think of it, I've known Jinho for a long time.

Six years? Seven? I wasn't sure. I'd never counted. Whenever I came back to the goshiwon[209] after a hard day, he was always there.

Sometimes I wondered if this was what it would have felt like to have a real older brother. We had lived like brothers, like friends.

"Hey."

Jinho broke the awkward silence. For no reason, I flipped the meat again.

"Yeah? What?"

"Good for you."

"…Yeah."

"And…"

His quiet voice followed.

"You worked hard."

Those few words were enough.

Something surged up from deep inside me. All the emotions and memories that had piled up over the past seven years came rushing in at once.

"Congratulations on becoming a C-rank Hunter. I guess I can't make fun of you anymore."

"Hyung…"[210]

"Taekyung…"

"Hyung!"[211]

"Taekyung!"

We hugged each other tightly across the grill. Jinho hyung[212] whispered in my ear, his voice shaking.

"Do you remember what I said earlier?"

"I know how you feel, hyung. Thank you."[213]

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[208] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[209] A *goshiwon* is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rooms, often rented by students or people on tight budgets.

[210] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[211] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[212] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[213] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

"Not that. The finder's fee."

"...What?"

"Make sure you pay me. Hyung's having a hard time these days."[214]

"..."

"You make a lot of money now."

Should I really kill him?

I staggered back to my room and threw myself onto the bed.

I let out a little laugh, thinking of the one person who was probably cleaning up the roof while grumbling.

You really can't let your guard down around him.

That was so like Jinho. The way he congratulated me, and the joke at the end.

I knew it was all just his way of expressing himself.

You worked hard.

Those words kept circling in my head. It was embarrassing to admit, but for a moment there, I had almost cried.

Yeah. I did work hard.

After my father died, I never stopped running. I worked part-time jobs while finishing high school, then kept enduring for the sake of my sick mother and little sister.

At some point, all of it had simply become a given.

And then—

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have been afflicted with the Status Effect Dead Drunk.

You can detoxify yourself by circulating your qi.

Something that wasn't a given had entered my life.

It had all started with that unidentified piece-of-junk game capsule.

"A game capsule, huh?"

I didn't even know what to call it anymore. It had made me a C-rank Hunter, so should I call it a gift from God?

No. Maybe it was a gift from the devil.

Is this really okay?

[214] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

Even after the best day of my life, the thought still occurred to me for one simple reason.

Nothing comes for free.

That was the world I knew. Everything came with a price tag. Whether you could see it or not, sooner or later, you had to pay.

How much does the System cost?

A hundred billion won?[215] A quadrillion won?[216] Maybe even more?

I laughed weakly as my eyelids grew heavy.

Oh, right. I was dead drunk.

Chirp. Chirp-chirp.

Outside the window, the grass insects were crying loudly. My vision darkened, and sleep poured over me.

That night, I dreamed.

I dreamed that somewhere deep in the mountains, someone was shaking me awake.

“Captain! Captain!”

There was something about that voice that made me want to punch its owner just from hearing it. At the same time, it sounded familiar, and part of me wanted to see who it belonged to, but I was too sleepy to open my eyes.

“What do we do?”

“We have to tell the main force at once…”

“Why is Captain suddenly like this now of all times…”

It felt like listening to a broken radio. The voices crackled with static and kept cutting out.

I’m sleepy…

As my consciousness drifted farther away, I heard a quiet but distinct voice.

“Youngest, stay alive.”

But when I woke the next day, I couldn’t remember any of it.

[215] A hundred billion won is about $71 million or €65 million.

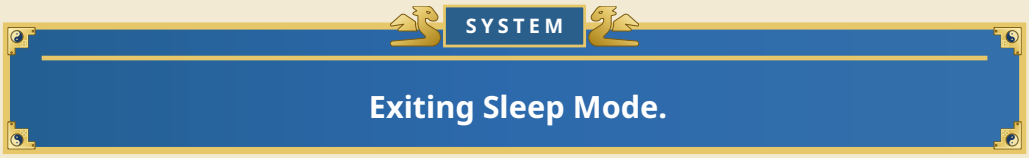
[216] A quadrillion won is about $710 billion or €650 billion.

Chapter 49

Early morning.

I eased my eyes open.

Ding.



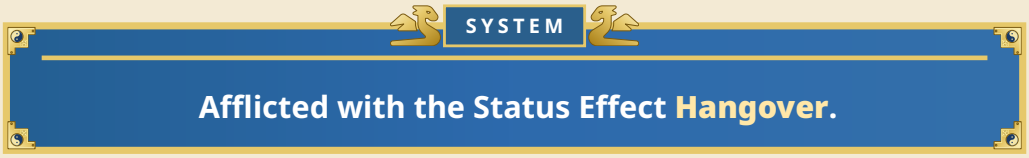
The System notification came with a sigh of relief.

“Phew.”

Thank goodness. It hadn’t all been a dream.

It had only been one day, but yesterday had changed my life. If I’d woken up as Jin Taekyung, F-rank Hunter, reality would have felt like a nightmare.

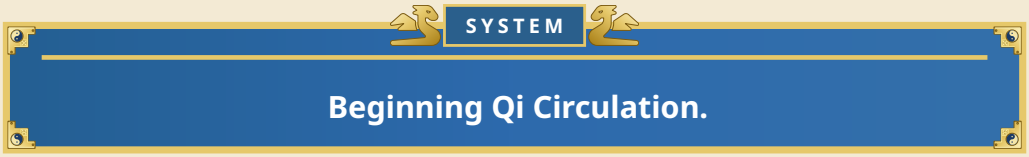
I rustled my way up—and that was when it hit.



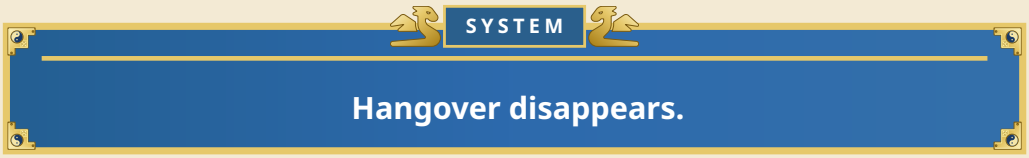
“Urgh.”

Last night’s aftermath was no joke. I clutched my spinning head and sat cross-legged on the mattress.

According to the System, circulating my qi could detoxify me, too.



Following the formula of the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique, I guided my internal energy. The moment I began circulating my qi, the headache started to fade. About ten minutes later, the message I’d been waiting for appeared.



But I didn’t stop. I knew that ending the circulation abruptly midway would make it less effective.

Something I learned in Murim.

A full hour passed before I finally uncrossed my legs. My head was clear, and my body brimmed with energy.

The problem was…

Why am I taking in so little qi?

To increase my internal energy, I had to draw in qi from outside, store it within myself, and circulate it. But during my first attempt in reality, strangely little qi had entered my body.

And it's murky, too.

It was like a tiny serving of bland food that took forever to arrive. I frowned.

Maybe it's the pollution?

Since internal energy was based on pure natural qi, that was possible. Compared to Murim, the natural environment of modern society was in dire shape.

Or maybe it's the location.

A single room in a decades-old goshiwon[217] was hardly a nature-friendly place. It stank, and the facilities were run-down.

Despite being the goshiwon[218] manager, Jinho hyung[219] was always questioning what this place had originally been.

"Maybe it used to be a torture chamber. During the Great Cataclysm, they probably dragged monsters in, tapped them on the balls with a knife, and asked where the Demon King was. They would've given up the location of the Demon King's parents, too."

…You had to give him credit for his imagination.

He should be sleeping by now, right?

He treated getting up in the morning as a disgrace, so there was no need to check. I was wondering whether to go grab breakfast when—

Bzzzt.

A text arrived on my phone.

> ㄴ 〈 Designer-Brand Junkie
> ㄴ Designer-Brand Junkie
> ㄴ Do you have some time?

The sender was Designer-Brand Junkie—or rather, Team Leader Choi.

[217] A goshiwon is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, often with shared facilities.
[218] A goshiwon is a Korean building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, often with shared facilities.
[219] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

A glittering chandelier. Stylishly dressed people. Soft classical music playing in the background.

I couldn't tell whether our meeting place was a café or a high-end restaurant.

"May I take your order?"

Shit. Even the waiter here looks like a celebrity.

He had a model's proportions and the face of a handsome Greek god.

Is this how everyone turns gay?

While I was experiencing an identity crisis, Team Leader Choi calmly placed his order.

"One Black Ivory, please. What about you, Mr. Taekyung?"

The Greek god turned toward me.

Something about the atmosphere made me feel like I shouldn't order a caramel macchiato.

"I'll have the same."

The coffee that arrived a little later was decent enough.

"It's good. This is Black… what was it?"

"Black Ivory."

Even after hearing the name again, I still had no idea what it meant. I just accepted it and moved on.

I muttered my honest take.

"It looks expensive. Do they use good beans?"

"It's elephant dung."

"Oh."

I quietly set down my cup. Team Leader Choi let out a short laugh, then spoke.

"Congratulations."

The congratulations came out of nowhere, but I immediately understood what he meant.

He was talking about yesterday's rank reassessment.

"You're fast. It's personal information—the Association wouldn't have opened all of it."

"C-rank reawakened Hunters are rare. Besides, I saw what happened yesterday with my own eyes. How could I not know?"

Fair enough.

As I nodded, Team Leader Choi held something out to me. A single envelope lay neatly on the table.

"What is this?"

"You'll know when you look."

Don't tell me—money?

I checked the contents. Instead of a check, tiny printed letters packed the page.

“It’s a contract.”

“These are the best terms our Guild can offer. Give it a read.”

I was already reading it, from the first line to the last. Every clause brought another surprise.

“This doesn’t look like a C-rank contract.”

After seven years in this business, I’d seen plenty and heard even more.

Yet even I had never seen a contract this generous.

“They’re good terms even among B-rank contracts.”

“Then why offer them to me…?”

“Because I trust myself.”

“What?”

“I trust my instincts and my eye for people. That’s why I want to sign you, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

Team Leader Choi set down his empty cup.

“Will you sign?”

Honestly, I was wavering. A lot.

It wasn’t only the terms. Someone had recognized me and wanted me this badly. I wanted to nod right then.

That was why I hesitated longer today than I had yesterday. By the time I finally made my decision, the coffee had gone cold.

“I’m sorry.”

My reason was the same as yesterday.

Under the contract, I would have to work as a Hunter affiliated with the Guild for at least one year.

I was grateful for the offer, but… I couldn’t rush this.

“Have you already signed with someone else? Or are you planning to?”

“No. I just need more time.”

“Time.”

Team Leader Choi sighed.

“I suppose it can’t be helped.”

I was about to apologize again when he said,

“Here’s my second offer.”

“Pardon?”

Team Leader Choi pulled another envelope from his jacket. Still dazed, I took it and checked the contents.

“A provisional contract?”

“You have a rough idea of what that is, right?”

Of course I did. I knew it well.

If the Manpower Office was day labor, a provisional contract with a Guild was temp work. You'd be attached to the Guild for a short stretch, basically a mercenary.

"You won't turn this one down too, will you?"

It wasn't quite as generous as the formal contract, but the terms were still excellent. More importantly, the contract period had been left blank.

"Write down whatever period you want."

"Oh. Right."

I took the pen he offered, still somewhat dazed.

After thinking it over, I wrote seven days. A week should be enough time to see whether the System would last.

Once I'd signed, Team Leader Choi held out his hand.

"I look forward to working with you."

"That's my line."

As we shook hands firmly, it finally sank in that I'd taken my first step as a C-rank Hunter.

Even if it's only a provisional contract.

My chest swelled with emotion.

"Should I come in tomorrow?"

"No."

Team Leader Choi tapped his watch.

"Starting now."

Vroom.

Team Leader Choi's car was a large military vehicle. He looked like the type to collect expensive supercars, so this was unexpected. I only understood why after we arrived at the Gate.

"Pick something."

"Pick what?"

"Equipment."

Team Leader Choi pressed a small button, and a trunk large enough for five grown men to lie down in appeared.

"I had it modified for work. Leaving all this at home felt kind of off."

I stared into the trunk with my mouth hanging open.

Holy crap.

Equipment worth at least several million won[220] was neatly stacked and sorted inside. Armor and weapons were only the beginning. There were all kinds of potions and even disposable magic scrolls that most people considered too expensive to use. He had everything.

"…Is all of this yours, Team Leader?"

"For now. Some were gifts, and I bought some because they looked nice."

Ah. So he bought equipment because it looked nice.

How rich do you have to be to think like that?

C-rank Hunters made good money, but Team Leader Choi's spending was already beyond that. He must have been rich enough that money was never a concern.

Gulp.

"I think I'd rather rent something. If I borrow yours and it gets damaged, it'd be a little…"

"They're out of fashion, so it doesn't matter."

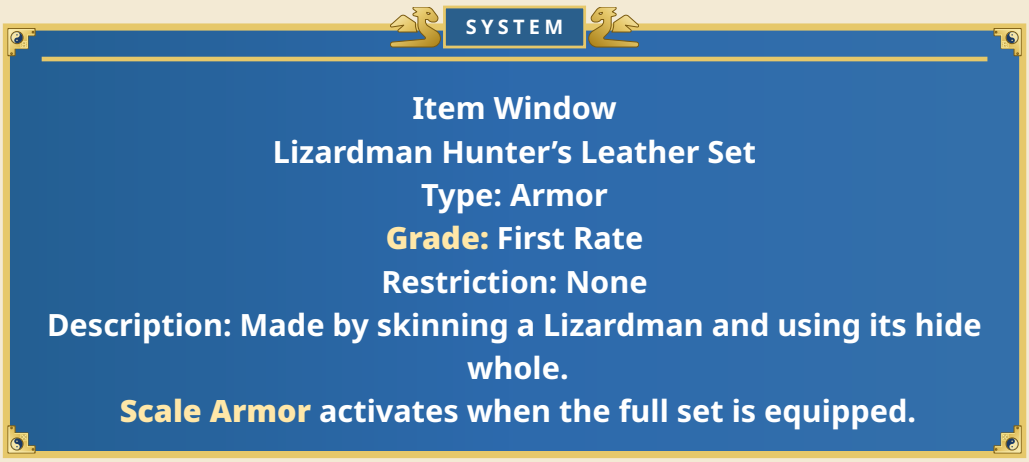
Ah. So he even cared whether equipment was fashionable.

I gave up thinking about it around there and picked my equipment.

The System made the process easy.

Item check.

Ding.



This looks pretty good.

It was light, and the leather was both tough and hard.

As soon as I put on the entire set, the **Scale Armor** effect activated.

"Oh."

Green scales rose from the leather, forming a dense layer over my entire body.

Team Leader Choi nodded when he saw me.

"You picked a good one. You've got a good eye."

It's the System that's good.

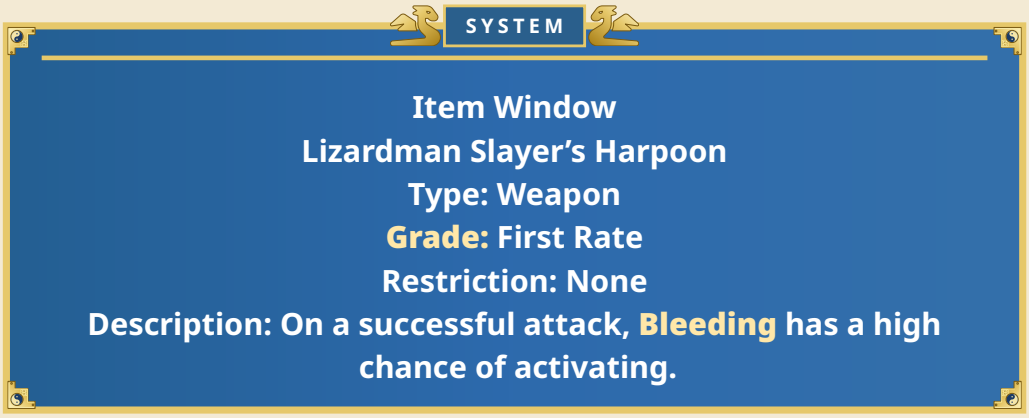
[220] Several million won is roughly 2–9 million won, or about $1,400–$6,400 and €1,300–€5,800.

I smiled awkwardly and rummaged through the weapons. Come to think of it, I'd only ever seen Team Leader Choi use a sword, but there were more than five types of weapons in the trunk alone.

They've all been used, too.

I could see traces of the effort he'd put into finding the weapon that suited him.

A little later, I found myself holding a spear.



Anyone who saw me would think I had a Lizardman fetish.

The spear completed my equipment selection. Team Leader Choi let out a short laugh.

"What's so funny?"

"I was just thinking that things are going well."

"Pardon?"

"You'll find out soon enough."

I had no idea what he meant, but I followed him to the front of the Gate. Instead of an Administration staffer, some man was standing there.

"You've arrived."

He bowed at a perfect ninety-degree angle. Even more surprising was how naturally Team Leader Choi accepted it.

"How's the Gate?"

"Yes. I received your call yesterday and restricted access."

"Thank you for your hard work."

"Not at all, Young Master."

That term could be used by a woman to address her husband's unmarried younger brother, but there was no way this man was Team Leader Choi's sister-in-law…

So Team Leader Choi was the young master of some rich family.

No wonder.

I should have realized it the moment I saw him decked out in luxury equipment from head to toe.

And being fashion-conscious enough to care about equipment design? You couldn't pull that off unless you'd been born with one hell of a gold spoon.

That guy has everything.

The man who had everything turned to me.

"All right. Let's go in."

"Right now?"

"The equipment is taken care of. Is there a problem?"

His tone made it sound so obvious that I looked around.

There was me, Team Leader Choi, and the unfamiliar middle-aged man. That was everyone.

"What about the other team members?"

"They're right here. The team members."

"Oh, I see. He's going in too, right?"

The middle-aged man cut in, his voice heavy.

"I'm not."

"Then…?"

"It's just the two of us. There's no one else."

Team Leader Choi's answer left me dumbfounded.

"No one else?"

"No."

"Not even one person?"

"We're not bringing so much as a dog."

Look at how decisive he was. Who was he, Judge Bao?[221]

"So the two of us are clearing the Gate alone?"

"Why not? It's only a D-rank Gate."

"This is my first D-rank Gate."

"I've been to plenty."

No, fuck…

A D-rank Gate wasn't some neighborhood discount store.

"If it's just the two of us, I'm backing out."

To raid a D-rank Gate safely, you needed a team of ten D-rank Hunters. I could use the System, and I'd learned martial arts, but that didn't eliminate every danger.

"I know what you're thinking, Mr. Jin Taekyung. But let me tell you one thing."

Team Leader Choi continued in a relaxed voice.

"I'm a reawakened Hunter, too."

"Reawakened? I thought you were C-rank, Team Leader…"

[221] Judge Bao, or Bao Zheng, was a Chinese magistrate celebrated in popular stories for impartial and uncompromising judgments.

“C-rank was what I received when I was first measured. My reawakening happened afterward.”

Meaning his abilities were at least B-rank.

The odds were slim, but he could be even higher.

A B-rank Hunter.

If that was true, the situation changed. Just the two of us also meant a bigger cut for me.

“If you want to go back, I won’t stop you. I can go in alone. It wouldn’t be the first or second time.”

He walked in and out of D-rank Gates alone on the regular?

“Then take care. Starting tomorrow, we’ll look for E-rank Gates.”

That sealed it.

I grabbed his shoulder as he turned away.

“Team Leader Choi.”

“Yes?”

“I want to… raid.”

Team Leader Choi smiled warmly.

“Let’s do our best.”

Chapter 50

My mouth fell open at the sight before me.

Amid the hot, humid air, wetlands stretched endlessly through dense forest.

“This is a D-rank Gate…”

I knew higher-ranked Gates contained larger spaces. I just hadn’t expected the difference to be this extreme.

“Big, isn’t it?”

I forgot all about being angry and answered.

“Yeah. Big enough to be daunting.”

“This is about average. Once you reach B-rank Gates, you even have to hire a separate guide.”

“…Feels like we need one now.”

“We’ll be fine today.”

Team Leader Choi pulled out a laminated sheet and showed it to me.

“What’s that?”

“A map. They gave it to me when the rights were transferred.”

A map. Then we wouldn’t have to worry about getting lost—

“Wait. What did you just say?”

“I said it was a map.”

“No, not that. What you said after that.”

“You mean the transfer of rights?”

Yeah, you. That.

“What does that mean?”

“Exactly what it sounds like.”

Team Leader Choi spoke as if it were no big deal.

“This Gate is mine.”

“What?”

“More precisely, I hold the exclusive rights to it.”

Maybe it was the wetlands. Sweat beaded on my palms, and my throat went bone-dry.

I swallowed a dry gulp.

Exclusive rights to a Gate?

In Korea, Gates were national property.

Since the Great Cataclysm, Magic Gems had become a core energy source, and Gates were essentially diamond mines that never ran dry. Yet this guy held the exclusive rights to one.

Who the hell is he?

I knew he was some rich family's young master, but I hadn't realized he was this rich.

"Let's get moving."

Team Leader Choi strode ahead. His back looked dazzling.

Ah, that golden radiance. The scent of untouchable wealth.

I'll bury my bones in your Guild.

I swore it then and there.

The wetlands were a maze.

Without a capable guide like Team Leader Choi, I would have wandered for a long time. How long had we been walking when—

- Keeiik.

The cry grew clearer as I drew up my internal energy.

A monster had appeared.

At least twenty.

According to Team Leader Choi's explanation on the way here, the monsters in this Gate were swamp Lizardmen.

They lived in several colonies under a single tribe, and this seemed to be one of them.

"This is the small colony closest to the entrance. There should be about twenty, so let's take them out quickly and move on."

Team Leader Choi hacked through the vines as he advanced. He was usually a pretty-faced young master, but once actual combat began, he was no joke. Watching him barrel forward like an eight-ton[222] truck with a broken steering wheel, I could practically smell the machismo.

He's fucking cool.

I felt like we could sweep aside not just thirty Lizardmen, but a hundred, as long as Team Leader Choi was with me.

Now I understood why people got high-level players to carry them in online games.

"Keiik!"

Maybe that was why I didn't feel particularly nervous when I came face-to-face with Lizardmen for the first time.

Mostly, I was fascinated to see monsters I'd only ever encountered in photos and videos.

"Oh, they're big."

[222] Eight metric tons is about 8,000 kg, or 17,600 lb.

Even the smallest of the twenty stood a head taller than me.

They were at least two meters[223] tall, with lean muscles and thick tails that made them look even larger.

Still not as big as the Hobgoblin Great Warrior I fought yesterday, though.

These hideous basketball prospects didn't seem too happy to see us.

- Keiik!
- Keet! Keet!

Dozens of harpoons flashed in their hands. I watched them approach from the front, spreading out to surround us.

"No archers."

"Swamp Lizardmen mostly use harpoons. They might throw them, so be careful."

"Yep."

As expected of a lizard expert. He even stood there with his arms casually folded.

"Keiik!"

They had closed to within twenty meters.[224] I grinned at Team Leader Choi.

"These guys have no fear."

"That's a Lizardman trait. They're reckless, and they prefer a head-on fight."

"Aha."

In the meantime, the distance shrank to ten meters.[225] Team Leader Choi's folded arms were starting to bother me.

"I think it's about time we started fighting."

"Guess we should."

"…Ah. Right. We should."

Whoosh!

Then three or four harpoons tore through the air. If I'd still been an F-rank Hunter, my life would have flashed before my eyes. Now I just swung my spear and batted them aside.

Clang, clang, clang!

That was when I noticed something strange.

- Kieeeik!
- Keet! Keiik!

What's wrong with them?

Their eyes rolled back until only the whites showed, and they shrieked wildly. This went beyond hostility. It was practically hatred.

As I stood there bewildered, Team Leader Choi casually remarked,

[223] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.
[224] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.
[225] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

"It's because of your equipment."

Equipment? What did my equipment—

Ah.

Lizardman Hunter's Leather Set. Lizardman Slayer's Harpoon.

Shit. Just look at those names.

If I were a Lizardman, I'd throw harpoons too.

Come to think of it, they only threw them at me.

With their people's mortal enemy standing right in front of them, they were treating Team Leader Choi like he was invisible.

At this rate, I was going to be the only one they attacked—

No, wait.

"Did you plan this?"

"Plan what?"

"You dressed me in this so I'd pull aggro while you mopped them up. That was your strategy all along, wasn't it?"

"I swear it wasn't."

Team Leader Choi's face turned serious as he added,

"I'm going to stand back and do nothing."

"What?"

"You'll pull the aggro and handle the raid. Don't get the wrong idea."

What the hell kind of bullshit is that?

"So… you want me to fight them alone?"

"Yes."

"While you stand there with your arms folded and watch?"

"I'll unfold my arms."

"No, for fuck's sake…"

"Harpoons incoming."

Whoosh!

Harpoons flew as green scales flashed from every direction and the Lizardmen charged.

Team Leader Choi sprang back and shouted with heroic gravity,

"You got this!"

Was this guy completely insane?

I wanted to run over and grab him by the collar, but harpoons were already flying at me from every direction.

Clang!

- Keiik!

"You bastards."

Grinding my teeth, I drew up my Qi Sense. Soon, twenty spears sprang up over their heads.

SYSTEM

Lv. 40 Lizardman Tribesman

Level 40, huh?

I tightened my grip on my spear.

“You’re all dead.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Damage dealt to this monster increases by 10% due to the effect of Lizardman Hunter’s Leather Set.

Damage dealt to this monster increases by 20% due to the effect of Lizardman Slayer’s Harpoon.

All Lizardmen in this Gate are hostile toward you. They will never stop until they have avenged this grudge!

At the same time, the Lizardman Slayer’s Harpoon traced a heavy arc. The forms of the Jin Family’s Spear Technique, now at Seven Stars,[226] poured toward them.

Crunch!

- Keiik…

The yellow reptilian eyes slowly closed.

The green wetlands were soaked with the corpses and blood of the ones already dead. Not a single Lizardman was left standing.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Level Up!

Level Up!

Leaving the cheerful System notifications behind, I turned around.

Team Leader Choi was leaning against a tree. He’d said he would unfold his arms, but there he was with them folded again. That made me twice as pissed.

[226] “Seven Stars” renders *chil seong*, a Korean expression indicating seven-tenths mastery here.

"What do you think you're doing?"

Team Leader Choi silently stared at me, then tossed something over.

A small drink bottle filled with red liquid. A potion that restored depleted Stamina.

"So first you make me sick, then you give me medicine?"

"You look rather healthy for a sick man. You don't have so much as a scratch."

...That actually sounded plausible. I almost let myself be convinced.

While I hesitated, Team Leader Choi spoke.

"I'm sorry."

He didn't stop there. He even bowed at the waist.

It was such a formal apology that I was left with nothing to say. My anger eased, but I still wanted to know why he had done it.

"Why did you do that?"

"I needed to see what you could do."

"Just for that?"

"It's important to me. I need to know how you move, how many enemies you can handle, and how far we can go together."

"So you just slipped out alone while it was crawling with monsters?"

"If I hadn't trusted you, I wouldn't have done it."

I had to admit, praise felt pretty good coming from someone as capable as him.

More importantly, I didn't get hurt, and I leveled up twice.

Trying not to sound too eager, I asked,

"So what's the verdict?"

"Hmm."

Team Leader Choi studied me with that peculiar look of his. At last, he spoke.

"I still don't know."

"What?"

"Which is why..."

Team Leader Choi pulled something out and tossed it to me.

It was a long, opaque cylinder. Liquid sloshed inside when I shook it.

"What's this, a potion?"

"There's a button on the bottom, right? Press it."

Does that open it?

I tilted my head and pressed the button.

Click.

The front of the cylinder sprang wide open.

The problem was—

Fwoooosh—

Boom!

Whatever had been inside shot up like a firework and burst in midair. The pink liquid exploded outward, spreading over a wide area.

"Huh?"

What is that?

As I stared blankly, Team Leader Choi's voice slipped into my ear.

"Pheromones."

"Pheromones? Like perfume?"

"Something like that."

"…?"

"They were extracted from female Lizardmen."

The instant he finished speaking, I felt a tremor from somewhere.

It was the ground. The ground was rumbling.

Team Leader Choi kindly added,

"They're extremely potent."

You bastard…

"Team Leader Three."

Those were the first words the half-gray, middle-aged man had spoken in an hour. Kim Sangshik, who had spent all that time waiting while the Guild Master chain-smoked, answered immediately.

"Yes, Guild Master."

"Curious, aren't you? Figured I called you in first thing this morning to raise hell?"

"Ah, no, sir."

The Sopung Guild Master smiled good-naturedly.

"You're right."

"What?"

"I called you to raise hell."

"…"

"Do you know where I went today?"

The Guild Master exhaled a plume of cigarette smoke.

"The Guild Alliance breakfast meeting."

Small and midsize Guilds were businesses too. In every region, Guild Masters held meetings to socialize and strengthen their alliances. Today had been one of those occasions.

"I went there on an empty stomach, and just as I was finally about to take a bite, that Sangdong Guild Master bastard told me something interesting. He said the C-

rank who awakened recently had been one of our Guild members until a few days ago.”

“…Guild Master, that’s—”

The Guild Master raised a hand, cutting Kim Sangshik off.

“I thought it was bullshit. The Sangdong Guild Master might be a rude bastard, but he’s not the type to make up stories. Especially not at an alliance meeting.”

“I-I’ll look into it again!”

“Team Leader Three? No. No need.”

The Guild Master flung a crumpled bundle of papers across the room.

“I already looked into it myself.”

Kim Sangshik recognized the crumpled papers for what they were: someone’s personal file.

He recognized the name on it too.

“Jin Taekyung. Team Leader Three knows that name too, right?”

Fuck.

Kim Sangshik squeezed his eyes shut as the Guild Master tapped the ash from his cigarette.

“I know how you feel, Team Leader Three. You’re a founding member of the Guild, after all. You’re allowed to fire one bottom-tier Hunter you don’t like. Stick your beloved son in the vacancy. Right?”

“Yes. Yes, sir.”

“But the F-rank loach you treated like dirt and kicked out turned into a dragon and came back, huh? I even made a point of telling you to recruit him, but if you told the truth I’d obviously raise hell. You’d get a reputation for having dog eyes that can’t even recognize someone. So you filed a false report, right?”

Sizzle.

The Guild Master crushed out his cigarette. As the embers scattered, the last of his patience vanished with them.

“Team Leader Three. No, Sangshik. Have we been together about twenty years?”

Kim Sangshik answered uneasily.

“Twenty-one years, Guild Master.”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“…Yes, hyung.”[227]

“Good. That sounds much better. Keep calling me that from now on.”

“What?”

“I’ve carried you for twenty-one years. I’ve done more than enough. I’ll speak to the rest of Team Three separately, so you’re leaving the Guild as of today.”

[227] *Hyung* is how a man addresses an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close relationship.

"H-hyung."[228]

"Shut your mouth, leave quietly, and I won't block your path. Once you're out, do whatever you want."

The Guild Master's voice was packed with tightly suppressed fury.

Kim Sangshik realized he had no other choice.

Leave? Leave the Guild?

He had spent more than twenty years at this job. And now he was being told to leave over something like this. Cast aside without a second thought.

Fuck…

He clenched his teeth and walked out of the office.

One last blow came after him.

"Hey, HR. Process two terminations today. Kim Sangshik and Kim Sangho."

For the next few days, Sopung Guild was in an uproar over the rare event of a father and son being forced out at the same time.

Along with that, the latest news about the bottom-tier Hunter who had recently left became the hottest topic in the Guild.

"They say he's C-rank now. Reawakening."

"Oh my, Mr. Taekyung? The Taekyung I know?"

"That's what I'm telling you. He hit the jackpot. Apparently Kim Sangshik went to recruit him without even realizing who he was and got flat-out rejected."

"He found every excuse he could to fire him, and now he's reaping what he sowed. I heard Team Leader Kim's been going around claiming he was wrongfully dismissed and badmouthing the Guild Master."

"He still hasn't come to his senses. Man, I'm jealous, though. When will I ever get to live a life like that?"

"Honestly, Taekyung deserves it. He worked so hard that luck finally found him."

"Deserves it, my ass. Then are the rest of us all just living it up? It's luck. All luck."

Half envy and half jealousy, the conversations always ended with the same question.

"Where is Mr. Taekyung now, and what's he doing?"

[228] *Hyung* is how a man addresses an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close relationship.

Chapter 51

Swish, swish, swish!

Swords, axes, maces.

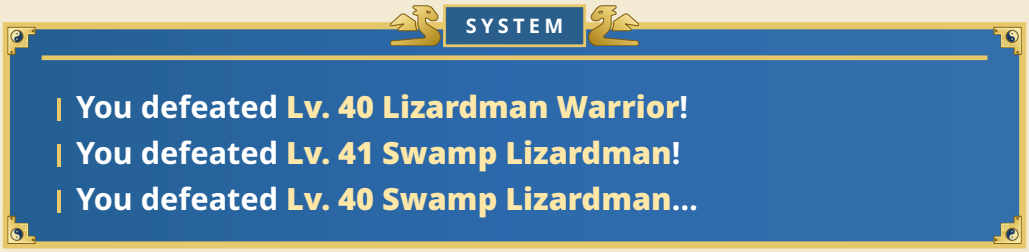
Dozens of weapons poured down like rain. But I could see every one of them clearly—where each attack was headed and how.

I slipped through the gaps.

Slice—

It started with me taking the head off a C-rank monster, a Lizardman Warrior. As the spearhead swept through a semicircle, blood spurted in every direction.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Keeee...

The survivors hesitated and backed away. The same creatures that had been pouring out killing intent at the enemy of their kin were now trembling with fear.

But that lasted only a moment.

Gwoooaar!

It was at least twice the size of the others, with a gigantic mace in its hand. The Lizardman Chieftain's roar exploded through the air. At the appearance of their leader, the retreating Lizardmen came to their senses and formed ranks.

I was wondering why this was wrapping up so easily.

Team Leader Choi's unhurried voice came from behind me.

"Can you handle it?"

"Is that something someone who hasn't lifted a finger for days should be asking?"

"This is different. It's a C-rank Gate."

"Then help, why don't you."

Team Leader Choi thought it over before answering.

“I don’t think I can. I’m wearing a limited edition today. It’d break my heart if blood splattered on it.”

“…Should I make it hurt for real?”

The longer we talked, the more my gut burned and the back of my head throbbed, as if I were suffering an Internal Injury. I’d rather fight the monsters.

As I took a long stride forward, Team Leader Choi tossed out a single line.

“Retreat is another option.”

The man standing behind me with his arms folded so blood wouldn’t splatter on his limited-edition Equipment had made a pretty good point.

The kind that made me want to hit him.

And then…

“Why bother when there’s a better way?”

Ahead of us, the monsters surged forward like a wave, led by the Lizardman Great Chieftain. C- and D-rank monsters mixed together—a force an ordinary C-rank Hunter wouldn’t even dream of facing.

An ordinary C-rank Hunter, that is.

Status Window, open.

Ding.

The System answered at once.

A week had passed since I’d started working as a Hunter again. On the Status Window, the number 40 and the line at the very bottom shone brightly.

Since returning to reality, I hadn’t spent a single Remaining Point. Purely out of curiosity.

How far can I go as I am now?

But hoarding them any longer would be reckless.

Assign 30 each to Strength and Stamina. Assign 40 to Agility.

The next moment, my Remaining Points hit zero.

In exchange, new power surged from deep inside me. I was no longer the same Jin Taekyung I’d been only seconds ago.

Yeah. This is it.

I was still trembling with exhilaration when—

Gwaaaar!

The Lizardman Great Chieftain charged with a roar. I thrust my spear toward the gigantic mace casting a shadow over me.

“One Annihilation.”

At the tip of my spear, a path through the wind opened.

“Hah.”

Team Leader Choi—Choi Minwoo—let out a hollow laugh.

A dense fog of blood hung over the wetlands, and beneath it lay the sprawled corpses of the monsters.

What the hell…

Dozens of monsters, including the boss, had been slaughtered in an instant. All of it by the spear of a C-rank Hunter who had reawakened only a few days ago.

Is something like this even possible?

It was a question he had carried since the day he first met Jin Taekyung.

That day, they had gone to an E-rank Gate without much thought. There, Taekyung had overwhelmingly overpowered a Rare Monster that normally took a couple of C-rank Hunters to bring down.

And on top of that, the strength he had shown over the past few days was…

Calling him a C-rank Hunter is a joke.

The reason Choi had begun raiding alone with Taekyung was simple.

He wanted to see how far this fascinating man could go.

And he wanted to keep anyone else from finding out.

But then a thought occurred to him.

Could he be stronger than me…?

No. No.

That was impossible.

Choi Minwoo forced the thought aside. Then Jin Taekyung caught his eye.

He was clutching the boss monster’s corpse—its upper body completely gone—and wailing in grief.

“No! My hide! This was expensive!”

…There was no way a man like that could be.

No. He *mustn’t* be.

Choi Minwoo suddenly felt cheated.

Burning Friday. *Bulgeum*, for short.

Other people in their twenties would be drinking in groups and drifting in and out of clubs. I spent it running Gates with Team Leader Choi.

Once in the morning. Twice in the afternoon.

By the time we finished three C-rank Gates and came back out, night had already fallen.

“Thank you for your hard work, Young Master.”

The face was familiar now. Team Leader Choi addressed the rugged-looking man in his forties like this:

“Thank you for your hard work too, Butler Kim.”

Butler Kim. Not a secretary—a *butler*.[229]

The word was so detached from reality that I thought I’d misheard it at first.

I’ve only ever met church deacons.

Back when I was a snot-nosed kid getting a thousand won[230] a week in allowance, one of them had been the bastard who forced me to hand over a hundred won[231] as a tithe.

Of course, he hadn’t called me Young Master. When I dug in and refused to pay, he’d even muttered that I was the child of Satan.

And at seven years old, I was the kind of kid who always asked when something made me curious.

“Mom. Are you Satan?”

“Huh? Satan?”

“Yeah. The church deacon said I was Satan’s child. I’m your kid, so that makes you Satan, right? Right?”

Those words turned my mother into Satan.

I never got to eat the church tteokbokki[232] again, and the church deacon nearly went to be with the Lord.

Thinking back on it, my life really had been one hell of a variety show.

“Did you have something to say…?”

Butler Kim’s voice pulled me back.

“Nothing. I was just thinking about something else.”

“Let’s call it a day.”

Team Leader Choi had already changed into street clothes. In a lightweight tailored suit, he looked just like a celebrity.

Life is so damn unfair.

I grumbled inwardly as I started taking off my Equipment. Carefully, of course. I’d looked up the price on the first day, and it was…

Never mind. Let’s not go there.

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[229] The Korean word *jipsa* can mean both butler and church deacon.

[230] A thousand won is about $0.71 or €0.65.

[231] A hundred won is about $0.07 or €0.06.

[232] *Tteokbokki* is a Korean dish of chewy rice cakes, usually served in a spicy sauce.

While Butler Kim loaded the Equipment into the car, I asked Team Leader Choi, “What time should I come in tomorrow?”

“Tomorrow?”

Team Leader Choi sounded puzzled.

“Today is Friday.”

“Yes.”

“And tomorrow is Saturday.”

“I know Saturday comes after Friday.”

Does he take me for a fucking idiot?

“No, I mean…”

Team Leader Choi furrowed his brow.

“Don’t tell me you’re planning to work this weekend too.”

“…Isn’t that obvious?”

“…”

“…”

Team Leader Choi asked with a shocked look,

“If you don’t take weekends off, when do you rest?”

“Um. When I can’t find work?”

“How often is that?”

“I don’t know. If I get a lot of time off, maybe once a month?”

“You used to belong to a Guild. You worked weekends then too?”

“I did if there was work.”

“Isn’t that a violation of the Hunter Labor Law?”

Even Team Leader Choi, who seemed perfect, didn’t know one thing.

How the world actually worked.

I let out a short laugh.

“What small or midsize Guild follows that to the letter? They all throw in extra pay and send you out on raids. Worked out for me, anyway.”

“Excuse me? You *liked* it?”

“I go to the day-labor agency on weekends. Getting extra pay from the Guild beats going there. They paid us cash on the spot to keep it off the books.”

“…”

“That’s just how it is.”

Team Leader Choi shook his head in disbelief.

“Our Guild follows the Labor Law. Provisional contracts are no exception.”

That’s a shame. Looks like I’ll have to go to the day-labor agency this weekend.

As I smacked my lips over the missed opportunity, Team Leader Choi gave me that peculiar look of his.

"Why do you push yourself so hard?"

"Why?"

"You're a C-rank Hunter now. You can afford to take it a little easier."

"That's…"

Because I don't know when the System might disappear.

I caught the words before they burst out of my throat. That was my secret—something I couldn't tell anyone.

"No particular reason. You have to row while the tide is in."

"If you keep working like that, you'll break the oars. Think about the people in the boat with you."

"The people in the boat with me? You, Team Leader?"

"Well, for example…"

Team Leader Choi paused before continuing.

"Your family, perhaps."

Family.

It was only one word, but warmth seeped into every corner of my body. We talked on the phone now and then, but I hadn't seen them in more than two months. Counting the time I'd spent in Murim, it had been three.

Has it already been that long?

Ever since my father died, my life had felt like a car driving uphill.

So I'd had no choice but to keep my foot on the gas. It felt as though I'd roll backward the moment I let up. As though the engine might die at any second.

"Anyway, weekends are off. Don't even think about going to the day-labor agency. Rest. That would be a contract violation."

"Oh. Okay."

Forcing me to rest this hard… Maybe this guy Choi isn't such a bad person after all…

No.

I couldn't let myself get taken in by a little emotional appeal. Not after all the hell I'd gone through on my own.

Team Leader Choi is an exploitative employer. An exploitative employer.

It was obvious he only wanted me resting on the weekend so he could work me to the bone starting next week. It was the mentality of a slave plantation owner who didn't want his worker wasting stamina somewhere else.

What a vicious man.

"Everything is ready, Young Master."

Butler Kim had returned after loading the Equipment.

That man's suffering under an exploitative employer too. It's almost ten at night, and he still hasn't gotten off work.

“Ah. What about the thing I mentioned?”

“I brought it.”

“Give it to him.”

At the exploitative employer’s command, Butler Kim held out the small box in his hands.

“Please take this, Hunter.”

To me.

“Huh? Me?”

It looked like a box of tonic drinks. I blinked at it until a thought flashed through my mind.

I asked carefully, “Don’t tell me this is money.”

“We contracted for weekly pay. Did you forget?”

I had. I’d assumed I would get it on Sunday.

I took the box, still dazed. It was heavy.

“Do you normally pay in cash?”

“Of course not.”

“Then…”

“You said you preferred cash, Mr. Jin Taekyung. Especially crisp new bills.”

I’d mentioned it in passing yesterday—or the day before. I hadn’t expected it to come back like this.

My opinion of the exploitative employer rose a little.

Of course, the most important part is still left.

Four days of pay, Tuesday through Friday. My first weekly paycheck as a C-rank Hunter.

Of course I was excited to find out how much it was.

I swallowed and opened my mouth.

“Then how much is all of this…?”

“I added a little extra on top of the contracted amount. The settlement details are inside, so check them. We’ll be going.”

“Until next time, Hunter.”

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim took off in a flash.

It all happened in an instant.

I stared after the receding car lights, bewildered, then opened the drink box. In the faint moonlight, thick bundles of bills caught my eye.

One, two, three…

The count stopped at six.

Six bundles of a hundred bills.

In other words, six million won.[233]

"What is this?"

Scam.

The word flashed through my mind. Just as my legs were about to give out—

"Huh?"

Had I seen it wrong? Why were the bills yellowish?

"Wait. Wait a second!"

I focused internal energy into my eyes, and my vision brightened.

Then I saw her.

A kindly smiling woman in a hanbok,[234] right there on the bill.

"Shin Saimdang![235] Wise mother and virtuous wife! Her son is Yulgok Yi I! Her husband is Yi Wonsu!"

I started speaking in tongues before I knew it.

This was insane. Completely insane.

One bundle held a hundred Shin Saimdang bills. Six of those meant…

"Th-three hundred million!"[236]

This time I couldn't catch myself as my legs gave out. I dropped to my knees with a thud and stared blankly into the drink box.

Under the bundles, a white sheet of paper lined the bottom.

Right. The settlement sheet!

I unfolded it in a panic.

It contained a complete record of the past four days' earnings.

Right down to the final amount being paid to me.

The settlement says thirty million won?[237]

What? Had I imagined it?

I was confused. Completely confused.

My shaking gaze froze on the final line.

Bonus: 270,000,000[238]

Then I remembered Team Leader Choi's last words before leaving.

I added a little extra on top of the contracted amount.

Thunder and lightning raged through my head.

I rose on trembling legs. Far off in the distance, the car's lights were already fading.

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[233] Six million won is about $4,300 or €3,900.

[234] A *hanbok* is traditional Korean clothing.

[235] Shin Saimdang (1504–1551), a Korean artist remembered as a model mother and wife, appears on South Korea's 50,000-won banknote (about $36 or €32).

[236] Three hundred million won is about $210,000 or €190,000.

[237] Thirty million won is about $21,000 or €19,000.

[238] The bonus is 270 million won, about $190,000 or €170,000.

They looked like a single ray of light.
“Ahh. Aaaah…”
Team Leader Choi.
No—he was the Light.

Chapter 52

Six in the morning.

Taxi driver Mr. Kim picked up his first fare of the day—and regretted it ten minutes later.

What rotten luck.

At first glance, the young man looked perfectly normal. He had a sturdy, muscular build and a clean-cut face. At most, he looked to be in his mid-to-late twenties.

But then…

"Sniff, sniff."

Something was off about him. Very off.

"Huuugh."

He was hugging a drink box like treasure, cracking it open every thirty seconds to smell it, then shuddering as if possessed.

What the hell is he doing?

A chill ran down the back of Mr. Kim's neck. He had been driving a taxi for more than ten years, but he had never encountered this particular breed of problem customer before.

Just as he stole another glance at the young man in the passenger seat—

"Mister."

"Y-Yes?!"

His heart nearly stopped.

The young man's eyes, hollow only a moment ago, now gleamed like a wild beast's.

"There's a truck behind us."

"A-a truck? A blue one?"

"Yes. Doesn't it look like it's been following us since that intersection?"

"Huh? Well, I suppose it does."

"It might be tailing us."

What fresh bullshit was this?

Mr. Kim's eyes darted around before he finally gave the answer the young man seemed to want.

"I-I'll peel off to the side."

The young man hugged the drink box tight until the blue truck disappeared from view, as if someone might snatch it away.

"Sniff. Sniff."

Of course, he didn't forget to smell it every chance he got.

This guy's completely insane.

The AC was blasting inside the car, but Mr. Kim's back was soaked with cold sweat. And this was his first fare of the day.

What a thoroughly cursed day.

Vroom.

The moment I handed over the fare and shut the door, the taxi shot off like a bullet.

Anyone watching would've thought a monster was chasing it. What if he got in an accident?

I clicked my tongue and headed into the apartment complex, still cradling yesterday's drink box against my chest.

Three hundred million won[239].

That was about as much as I'd saved over three full years as an F-rank Hunter. Of course, I didn't have a single won[240] of it left now.

I spent it all paying off debts.

There had been a time when I was drowning in debt, but I'd gritted my teeth and kept going until things gradually got better. I'd even moved my family into a safe-zone apartment near Ilsan.

Lately, though, my life had been like a roller coaster.

A roller coaster that would plummet if the System disappeared…

No. I was home for the first time in months. I needed to stop thinking about that.

Which building and unit was it again?

I only came by once every couple of months, so this always happened.

I glared at the tightly packed apartment buildings, then pulled out my phone and called. It rang for quite a while before the line finally connected.

Click.

"Hello?"

I'd expected Hayeon to still be asleep this early, but her voice was perfectly clear.

"You were already up?"

"Of course I'm up. Do you know what time it is?"

"It's not even seven."

"I study better when I wake up early."

My little sister never failed to impress me. Jinho hyung[241], who considered waking up in the morning one of the seven deadly sins, should've heard that.

"Why'd you call?"

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[239] About $210,000 or €190,000.

[240] One won is about $0.00071 or €0.00065.

[241] *Hyung* is how a younger man addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

“I’m out front.”

“Huh? Out front?”

“Yeah. But I forgot which one is ours.”

“…Again? You really are something. Wait there.”

I stood there holding the dead phone. A few minutes later, a girl emerged from the entrance of one of the buildings, dragging her slippers along.

Even from a distance, she radiated the aura of a total bum. The look on her face said that everything in the world was too much trouble, and I couldn’t help laughing.

“Jin Hayeon!”

“Don’t yell. You’ll wake people up.”

…Yeah. That was my little sister.

“What brings you here? You didn’t even tell us you were coming.”

“Do I have to announce it before coming to my own house?”

“You show up so rarely. The women’s association president probably visits more often than you do.”

“That bad?”

“That bad.”

The elevator stopped. Hayeon punched in the code at the front door and turned the handle.

And there—

“Son!”

Someone stood beaming at me.

Wrinkled hands. A perm half fallen out. She looked as delighted as a child receiving a surprise gift.

My throat tightened. I scratched my chin, then burst out laughing.

“I’m home, Mom.”

I had finally come back.

To the place where my family was waiting.

Home.

Sizzle, sizzle.

Mom was busy with breakfast in the kitchen. A good smell hung in the air.

“Look at Lady Kim, all excited because her son’s finally home.”

Hayeon scratched her stomach and plopped down beside me.

The old sofa sagged beneath her.

What a pig.

"Is she making a lot?"

"Yeah. A whole feast. Looks like we're eating well today."

She answered without taking her eyes off her phone.

"You haven't seen your brother in ages. Aren't you happy to see me?"

"Huh?"

"I mean, you could at least massage my shoulders after everything I've been through."

Hayeon let out a long sigh.

"What's gotten into you, Mr. Taekyung? We don't have that kind of relationship."

"…Listen to that attitude."

It wasn't like we'd only started bickering yesterday, but I still felt a pang.

I mean, I'd barely made it home after nearly dying!

"That got to you just now, didn't it?"

Her radar was scary.

"Go get ready for school, you little cafeteria parasite."

"Mm. Today's the school founding anniversary."

My fist trembled.

I wanted to smack the back of her irritating head right then and there, but if I did, I'd really lose.

"You want to hit me, don't you? Your fist is shaking."

"You're lucky you're a girl. If you had balls, I would've—"

"Mom! Oppa[242]'s sexually harassing me!"

"Hey, hey!"

"He said b—mmph!"

I clamped a hand over Hayeon's mouth. She thrashed, hitting and pinching me, but she was still just a nineteen-year-old girl. It didn't hurt.

Then one of her flailing feet accidentally slammed into the drink box I'd carefully set in the corner of the sofa.

Thump.

Flutter.

The box sprang wide open.

Yellow bundles of bills spilled across the living-room floor.

Hayeon froze.

"Come on, stop fighting and eat your breakf—"

Mom had come out of the kitchen too.

Everything in the living room stopped as if someone had hit pause. Only the quiet simmering of the stew filled the silence.

[242] *Oppa* is how a younger woman addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

Sizzle, sizzle.

I smiled awkwardly and opened my mouth.

“Can’t we talk about this after breakfast?”

“…Son?”

“Mmph, mmph, mmph.”

It looked like breakfast would be delayed for quite a while.

I told my family a suitably edited version of everything that had happened so far.

My reawakening as a C-rank Hunter, and where the money had come from.

“So that’s what happened.”

Their reactions fell into two categories.

“I see.”

Mom nodded blankly.

And then—

“Proof.”

“…”

Yeah. I hadn’t expected anything else from you.

I sighed and tossed Hayeon my wallet.

“What’s this?”

“Take a look.”

She eyed me suspiciously, then started rummaging through it. There was barely anything inside, so it didn’t take her long to find *it*.

“Whoa.”

A single card in her hand.

It was the C-rank Hunter license the Association had issued me two days ago.

“This isn’t fake, is it?”

“Want to get hit?”

“Guess it’s real.”

“Forging one is a serious crime, you idiot.”

“What about the money? Did that Team Leader Choi or whatever his name is really give it to you, like you said?”

“How many times do I have to tell you before you believe me?”

“About three hundred and fifty?”

Despite what she said, she seemed to believe me now.

[243] About $210,000 or €190,000.

A silver C-rank Hunter license. Three hundred million won[243] in neatly stacked bundles.

Every bit of it looked completely out of place in this old, cramped living room.

Mom sat there staring blankly and muttered, almost a groan.

“What on earth is all this…?”

Hayeon let out a hollow laugh like an old woman who had seen everything life had to offer.

“I know. Live long enough and you see everything.”

“You’re not even twenty.”

“It’s just an expression. But, Mom.”

“Y-Yes?”

“I smell something burning.”

“Oh, right! The stew!”

Mom’s half-lidded eyes flew open. I hurried to my feet, but the kitchen was already a disaster zone.

Mom followed me in, stomping her feet.

“Oh no! What do we do?”

The broth had boiled down to almost nothing, and the fish had turned into lumps of charcoal. I’d been looking forward to a home-cooked meal after so long, but…

Well, this wasn’t such a bad turn of events either.

“Let’s go out to eat. It’s been a while.”

Normally, Mom would’ve launched into a long speech about the absurd price of restaurant food, while Hayeon would’ve asked us to order fried chicken instead. This time, they both stayed quiet.

“Little sister.”

“Yes, dear brother.”

“Grab the money.”

“Yessir.”

As if she’d been waiting for the order, Hayeon swept up the bundles of cash.

“I’m sorry, but our restaurant has a dress code…”

The manager of the upscale restaurant—where a course meal cost several hundred thousand won[244] per person—gave us an awkward smile.

“A dress code?”

“Yes. As you can see, all our other guests are dressed accordingly.”

[244] Several hundred thousand won—roughly 300,000–900,000 won—is about $210–$640 or €190–€580.

He was right. Men and women alike wore suits and dresses. Some were even in evening gowns.

Shit. Anyone watching would think they'd come to dance at a ball.

What was this, eighteenth-century France?

For someone like me, who'd only ever gone to gukbap[245] places, it was a massive culture shock.

"Let's just go somewhere else."

"Yeah. Hayeon knows a lot of good restaurants around here."

My family seemed even more embarrassed than I was, so I simply walked out.

The three of us were reflected in the restaurant glass. We'd clearly dressed up for our first meal out in a long time, but every piece we owned was cheap market-brand stuff that already looked well-worn.

Had they been that short on money?

I'd sent most of what I earned home while cutting back on my own food and clothes.

Even when I was an F-rank Hunter, I'd worked twice as hard as everyone else. It couldn't have been a small amount.

"Son, should we go get pork belly? Maybe something greasy is a bit much this early in the morning."

"Pork belly sounds good. Mom knows what's what. A friend of mine went to the barbecue place at the intersection up ahead and said it was amazing."

Just pork belly.

I had a C-rank Hunter license in my wallet and a bag stuffed with cash. They knew that. They could afford to splurge without worrying.

That's why I work.

Someone once said money couldn't buy happiness. That happiness didn't come with a price tag.

Personally, I had one thing to say to people who spouted that crap.

Fuck off.

You can't spend money when you don't have any.

After spending all night wondering what to do with it, I'd finally made up my mind.

For today, at least, I would spare no expense on my family.

And now, that resolve swelled even stronger.

"Let's eat a little later."

Without waiting for an answer, I flagged down a passing taxi.

"Where to?"

[245] *Gukbap* is a Korean dish of rice served in hot soup.

“Mirae Department Store.”

It was supposedly the biggest and most expensive department store in the area. In the rearview mirror, Mom’s eyes widened.

“The department store?”

Meanwhile, the corners of Hayeon’s mouth curled up slyly.

“Nice. My rich oppa[246] can buy me clothes too.”

Sharp as ever. She caught on immediately.

I gave a short laugh.

“Buy whatever you want.”

“Really?”

“Pick out Mom’s things first.”

“Okay.”

“You’ve got yourself a devoted son, ma’am. Ha ha.”

Only then did Mom smile at the driver’s banter.

“You’re really buying everything?”

“Everything.”

Once I confirmed it one last time, Hayeon tore through the department store like a colt off its reins. She scanned the clothes with a terrifyingly keen eye and moved so fast I started to wonder if she was an Awakened.

At first, Mom looked at the price tags more than the clothes. Before long, though, she started joining in enthusiastically.

“Mom, what do you think of this?”

“Isn’t it too short?”

“This one!”

“That’s nice.”

“This too!”

“That’s pretty. Excuse me, miss—do you have this in one size larger?”

Two hours later, I began to feel a change in my body.

I’m dying.

For reasons I couldn’t explain, I was suffering from extreme shortness of breath and agonizing pain in my legs.

A sense of helplessness comparable to what I’d felt facing Jopil in Murim engulfed my entire body.

“Oppa[247], how do I look?”

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[246] *Oppa* is how a younger woman addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

[247] *Oppa* is how a younger woman addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

“Ugly. Get lost.”

“Son, try this on.”

“I don’t think I need to. I’ll take it.”

I have no idea how many clothes we bought that day or how much we spent.

All I know is that by the time we finished shopping, one of the department store’s top executives came to see us off.

“Welcome.”

The manager of the restaurant with the strict dress code didn’t even recognize us.

“Wow, I’ve never eaten anything like this before.”

“I know. How do they make the food look so pretty?”

Mom and Hayeon whispered to each other, their cheeks flushed.

We’d spent dozens of times more than the several-hundred-thousand-won[248] course meal just so we could eat it, but not a single won[249] felt wasted that day.

“But I want rice. This is too rich.”

“Why are the portions so small?”

…I pretended not a single won[250] felt wasted.

[248] Several hundred thousand won—roughly 300,000–900,000 won—is about $210–$640 or €190–€580.

[249] One won is about $0.00071 or €0.00065.

[250] One won is about $0.00071 or €0.00065.

Chapter 53

Ding.

"...O-oppa!"[251]

I gasped and opened my eyes.

The first thing I saw wasn't the ceiling of my goshiwon[252], but Hayeon's face.

Oh, right. I came home yesterday.

"Did you have a nightmare?"

"Huh?"

"You were screaming earlier. And you were sweating like crazy."

I was?

Before I could ask, I realized my whole body was soaked in sweat, and my throat stung as if I'd swallowed sand.

Why do I feel like this?

The System didn't only work while I was awake. Sleep Mode let me sleep deeply while restoring me to peak condition.

Nothing like this had ever happened in Murim or since Synchronization. And a nightmare, on top of that?

What did I even dream about?

My head throbbed, but I couldn't remember the dream at all.

Hayeon asked worriedly, "Has something bad happened lately?"

"No. Nothing like that."

"If there is, tell me. Don't suffer by yourself."

"Yes, nuna."[253]

"I'm not joking."

Her little fist thumped my chest. Faced with Hayeon's serious expression, I had nothing to say. I scratched my chin.

"Really? Nothing bothering you? Nothing giving you a hard time?"

"I told you, there's nothing."

---

[251] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man.

[252] A *goshiwon* is a small, inexpensive rented room, typically in a building with shared facilities.

[253] *Nuna* is a Korean term a boy or man uses for an older sister or a close older woman. Taekyung uses it jokingly for his younger sister.

It was a lie. There had been things seven years ago, and there would be things seven years from now. There had been days when I locked myself in my room and cried, and days when I drank myself senseless with Jinho just to forget.

That's enough.

There were things I couldn't tell my mother, who had worked until the cartilage in her knees wore down raising the two of us, or my little sister, a high-school senior now preparing for her college entrance exam.

Enduring things alone and overcoming them. I was used to it by now.

I flashed her a grin as if nothing was wrong.

"My life's finally about to take off. What would I have to worry about? Ah, there is one thing. How I'm supposed to spend all this money. Something like that."

"Big talk."

The mood lightened a little. I made a face on purpose.

"Big talk? Don't you remember yesterday? Want me to show you the bundles of cash again?"

"I'll give you that. You're obnoxious, but I can't argue."

"I've hit the peak of my twenty-seven-year life graph. Nothing's going on, so you just study hard."

"My grades are in the top 0.1 percent nationwide, okay? I'm doing more than well enough, so don't worry."

Hayeon pouted and started to leave, then stopped and turned back.

"Oppa. But…"

"Yeah?"

"Who's Jin Wikyung?"

"…What?"

A name I never expected, at a moment like this.

My body went rigid.

Crunch.

I bit into a piece of freshly made young-radish kimchi. It was Mom's cooking, the food I'd wanted so badly, but I could barely taste it.

Because of the conversation I'd just had with Hayeon.

"Where did you hear that name?"

"From you. You kept saying it in your sleep."

And then her final question.

"Someone you know? If they show up in your dreams, you must be close."

I couldn't answer. I hadn't found that answer in Murim or in reality.

No. I no longer had any reason to look for it. I had returned to reality, and Jin Wikyung was in Murim.

Then why did Jin Wikyung suddenly show up in my dream…?

My thoughts were a mess. Was it some aftereffect of Murim? The term PTSD came to mind—post-traumatic stress disorder.

This is driving me crazy.

My expression must have hardened without my noticing. Mom asked gently, “Have you lost your appetite? I made all your favorites.”

“Oh, no. When did you make the kimchi? And this doenjang-jjigae[254] is perfect.”

I hurriedly made excuses and picked up my spoon. For the first time in ages, the three of us were together at one table. I couldn’t ruin this precious moment.

It’s nothing. It has to be nothing.

Slurp.

Even so, the savory doenjang-jjigae[255] tasted faintly bitter.

The unease nagging at the back of my mind soon faded, and I went back to normal.

I laughed and talked with my family all day. I even took a long nap, and by the time I woke up, it was evening.

Time to go back.

“Stay a few more days. I was going to make boiled pork tomorrow.”

“There goes Lady Kim again. I know how to eat boiled pork too, you know?”

Hayeon grumbled at the reluctance dripping from Mom’s words.

“She packed you a ton of side dishes already, so why are you so worried? At this rate, she could open a side-dish shop.”

“…That’s true.”

The shopping bags Mom had prepared by the front door were packed with side dishes. Even this much was a compromise I’d only managed to reach after talking her down.

I don’t have anywhere to put them.

If I put a fridge in my three-pyeong[256] goshiwon[257] room, there really wouldn’t be anywhere left to stand. No—there wasn’t even room for a fridge.

I already had a capsule the size of one.

Should I start looking for a new place?

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[254] *Doenjang-jjigae* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybean paste.

[255] *Doenjang-jjigae* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybean paste.

[256] One *pyeong* is about 3.31 m^2 (35.6 ft^2); three pyeong is about 9.93 m^2 (107 ft^2).

[257] A *goshiwon* is a small, inexpensive rented room, typically in a building with shared facilities.

I was thinking that as I slung the backpack I'd packed the night before over my shoulder.

"…?"

Why was it so heavy? All I'd put inside were a few outfits I'd bought yesterday.

When I set the backpack down, my family suddenly grew frantic.

"Son, you'll be busy starting tomorrow, right? Hurry back, wash up, and get a good night's sleep."

"…A minute ago, you told me to stay a few more days."

"Oppa, you're going to miss your ride."

"I'm taking a taxi, though?"

"The late-night surcharge. You'll have to pay the late-night surcharge."

By then, I had a pretty good idea what was going on.

"When did you put it in?"

"P-put what in?"

"The money."

Their faces answered for them. I sighed.

"I told you to keep it and use it when you need it."

"…"

"I make plenty of money. And I will from now on, too."

I mixed fact and fiction fifty-fifty.

The average annual salary of a C-rank Hunter was five hundred million won.[258] I'd met a generous employer in Team Leader Choi and received a bonus beyond anything I could have imagined, but if the System disappeared, all of it would go up in smoke.

That was why I'd wanted to give even more to my family, but…

"That's money you risked your life to earn. Spend it on yourself. All right?"

"Mom."

"Son."

Then Mom spoke quietly, leaving me at a loss for words.

"Don't push yourself. And don't get hurt. That's all Mom needs."

What else was I supposed to say?

A little later, I stepped out into the humid summer night.

With shopping bags full of side dishes and a backpack stuffed with bundles of cash.

Vroom.

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[258] Five hundred million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[259] A *goshiwon* is a small, inexpensive rented room, typically in a building with shared facilities.

Throughout the taxi ride back to the goshiwon[259], I thought about Mom's final words and the warmth in them.

And about a voice from a memory that was growing fainter and fainter.

"Survive. I'm telling you to run without looking back. That's your mission."

Shaaah—

Blood spurted.

Not the green blood of a monster, but red human blood. Fighting through the burning pain in my thigh, I rammed my spear into the Lizardman Chieftain's chest.

"Keee…"

Ding.

SYSTEM

You defeated Lv. 50 Lizardman Chieftain!

You gained EXP!

Gate cleared. A mana field leading outside formed over the Lizardman Chieftain's lifeless body.

That was when Team Leader Choi pushed away from the tree.

"Three."

"Pardon?"

"The number of times you've been injured today, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

His long, sturdy fingers pointed to each wound on my body.

The nape of my neck and my arm, already treated with potions, and my thigh, which was still bleeding.

"I'm fine. They were only grazes. A low-grade potion is more than enough…"

"You're not fine."

He cut me off firmly. Team Leader Choi's expression was always unreadable, but this time something was different.

One thing was certain. The emotion showing on his face wasn't simple concern.

"You weren't injured even once last week. Same Gate, same monsters. If this is happening, there can only be one reason."

His clear eyes fixed on me.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung. Is something wrong?"

One day. Two days. Three days.

Time passed, but things didn't improve. On the fourth day, I ended up injured in five different places.

"Not in your current condition. Go home."

Leaving Team Leader Choi's words behind, I headed for the goshiwon[260], my head a mess.

What's the problem?

Everything had been going well. The System hadn't disappeared, and I had roughly three hundred million won[261] deposited in the bank. All that remained was to keep riding high as a C-rank Hunter, but…

Those damn dreams.

That was when it started. Ever since my first night at my family's house, I'd been having nightmares.

The scenes in them grew clearer by the night, and every time a dream ended, I woke up soaked in sweat. Even if I circulated my qi and restored my physical condition, my unstable mind only made me commit more mistakes.

This is going to be a problem.

My body was in reality, but my mind was still trapped in Murim. I was wondering whether I should see a psychiatrist when I reached my goshiwon[262] room.

Click.

"Oh, you're back?"

The greeting was so natural that I almost wondered whether I'd walked into the wrong room.

I asked, incredulous,

"What are you doing?"

Jinho answered, "Disassembly and reassembly."

He was sitting in front of the capsule with a screwdriver. For a second, my vision went yellow.

This bastard isn't actually—

"Are you crazy? Move!"

"Hey, hey. Hear me out."

Jinho hurriedly waved his hands.

"I haven't even started yet."

"What?"

"I just got here too. Seriously."

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[260] A *goshiwon* is a small, inexpensive rented room, typically in a building with shared facilities.
[261] Three hundred million won is about $210,000 or €190,000.
[262] A *goshiwon* is a small, inexpensive rented room, typically in a building with shared facilities.

He didn't look like he was lying. Only after I checked that the capsule was still intact did a sigh of relief escape me.

"Phew."

Jinho looked taken aback by my reaction.

"Why are you making such a fuss over one junk capsule that doesn't even work? What happened to tossing it out like a piece of luggage?"

"That was then."

There was no way Jinho could know about Synchronization, or what that unidentified object—nothing but a junk capsule to him—meant to me.

"Anyway, don't touch it. Got it?"

"You look ready to beat me to death."

"I'll tear you to pieces."

"…"

I ignored Jinho's baffled expression and flopped onto the bed.

After that little episode, it felt like all the energy had drained out of me.

"Something going on?"

"Going on, my ass."

"Complaints about you have been no joke lately. Today, I barely managed to calm down the guy next door and send him away."

I could guess why.

Jinho gathered up the tools he'd scattered across the floor and continued.

"He says he's going crazy because you groan all night. Oh, and he asked who Jin Wikyung is."

That name again.

I buried my face in the pillow.

"Just tell him she's my girlfriend."

I saw his hand tremble around the monkey wrench.

"You got a girlfriend? You traitorous bastard."

"…"

"Is she pretty? How old is she? Show me a picture."

This guy was thirty. It was tragic.

"The name's a bit exotic, though. Is she an ethnic Korean from China? Or Chinese?"

"…Chinese."

It wasn't exactly wrong.

"This bastard hits C-rank and he's already gone global. Anyway, introduce me to a girl. I like China. Nǐ hǎo ma?[263] Wǒ ài nǐ.[264] What else was there?"

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[263] *Nǐ hǎo ma?* is Mandarin Chinese for "How are you?"

[264] *Wǒ ài nǐ* is Mandarin Chinese for "I love you."

"You fucking bastard."

"Idiot. You got the tones and pronunciation all wrong. You think you'll even make it to a hundred days[265] like that? Repeat after me. Nǐ chī fàn le ma?"[266]

"You fucking bastard."

"Again. Nǐ chī fàn le ma?"[267]

"You fucking bastard."

"…Wait, you bastard!"

I ignored Jinho, enraged by his belated realization, and pointed at the door.

"Get out."

Please. Just let me have some time to myself.

Once the room was quiet, I sat up and walked over to the capsule. I tapped its old, grime-caked surface and muttered, "What the hell are you?"

As expected, no answer came.

I'd secretly been hoping for one. What a shame.

The System's already synchronized with reality. Why couldn't a machine talk too?

Honestly, I wasn't even sure it was a real machine. Reality had turned into fantasy a long time ago, but wasn't this a whole new genre?

If I wrote my current situation as a novel, what genre would I even pick? Fantasy? A game novel? Or—

Dimensional travel?

A hollow laugh escaped me. Dimensional travel? I really was losing it. There was no way something like that was possible.

There was no way…

My mind snapped clear as if someone had dumped ice water over my head.

…It is possible.

Dimensional travel had happened in the past, and it still existed now.

The invasion of the Demon King Asmodeus and the Gates were proof.

We only passed through Gates to leave and return to our world, but decades ago, an army of monsters had crossed through one from another dimension to Earth.

The Demon Realm.

A land of evil. The home of monsters. The Demon King's domain.

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[265] In Korea, couples commonly mark their hundredth day together as a relationship milestone.

[266] *Nǐ chī fàn le ma?* is Mandarin Chinese for "Have you eaten?" Its pronunciation resembles a Korean profanity, which Taekyung keeps saying instead.

[267] *Nǐ chī fàn le ma?* is Mandarin Chinese for "Have you eaten?" Its pronunciation resembles a Korean profanity, which Taekyung keeps saying instead.

An unknown dimension no human had ever set foot in or even glimpsed. That was how humanity defined it.

But what if this capsule in front of me was a kind of Gate leading to another dimension? What if Murim was another unknown dimension?

Murim is another reality.

Everything I had seen and experienced there.

Water. Earth. Wind. And people, too.

They weren't NPCs.

I stared at my vacant face reflected on the capsule's faded surface.

For a long while after that.

Chapter 54

It felt like watching an old TV.

Scenes and voices stuttered across a faded screen, cutting in and out. Even so, the heat of the battlefield came through vividly.

“Kill them!”

“Destroy the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

The people packed into the narrow gorge charged forward with a roar. Behind them, a flag marked *Mount Heng* whipped in the air.

Beyond the points of their blue-edged weapons stood another banner.

Jin (□).

And hundreds of martial artists sealing off the gorge.

“They’re bastards with neither martial honor nor chivalry. The Mount Heng Sword Sect disappears today!”

“Attack!”

Static crackled.

The view zoomed in through the noise, locking onto two people who stood out beneath the flag of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

An old man with a long white beard spoke.

“This will be a long fight.”

A massive man answered.

“And our last.”

The old man broke into a broad smile.

“It will be. Without fail.”

Then—

People crashed into people, swords into spears. Countless martial artists collided, and a thick mist of blood settled over the gorge.

Somewhere, drums thundered to announce the start of the battle.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

“Hah.”

I sat up, drenched in sweat. Another dream about Murim.

Unlike at first, I could now remember the dream clearly even after waking.

The battle has begun.

Time continued to pass in Murim even after I returned to reality.

The scenes I had just witnessed might be happening there right now. A great battle with the fate of two immense powers hanging in the balance.

No. There's one more.

A third force led by the Head Elder.

Once the battle reached its climax and both sides had suffered heavy losses, that was when they would finally move.

What about Hyuk Mujin? What happened to the reconnaissance squad?

If they arrived in time and exposed the betrayal, the worst could still be avoided. Or they might already be too late, and everything might be over.

The Head Elder…

An old man who had given me the creeps from the first impression. Who would have thought that so-called elder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan would be plotting something like this?

If the Head Elder emerged as the final victor, it would all be over.

A rebellion was always followed by a bloody purge.

Jin Wikyung, Wipeng, Hyuk Mujin, and the reconnaissance squad.

Then there was Han Yeop, too badly injured in his fight with Jopil to march out, as well as Gong Yacheong and the siblings Socheon and Soyul, who were still recovering.

Familiar faces appeared and vanished in my mind, over and over.

What were they to me?

One month in Murim.

To them, I had been a Benefactor, a trusted superior, and a comrade they could trust to watch their backs. And to someone…

"I'm proud of you."

"Are you hurt anywhere?"

"Survive, my youngest."

We were also brothers by blood.

But what had they been to me? NPCs loaded with advanced AI? Or people?

What were they?

Another dimension only I could come and go from, and the people left behind there. What was I supposed to do about that?

My eyes drifted to the capsule on their own.

What if I went back…?

The thought startled me.

I was out of my mind.

Go back and do what? This was a massive battle involving some two thousand martial artists. Among them were monsters as strong as Jopil, One Question, One Kill—or even stronger.

And I was thinking of going back there?

“You lunatic. You crazy bastard. You’ve completely lost it.”

I was muttering the words like a sigh when my phone buzzed.

Bzzz.

Designer-Brand Junkie.

It was Team Leader Choi.

A large café surrounded by downtown skyscrapers.

“Here are the materials you requested.”

Butler Kim held out a thick binder. Even at a glance, it looked like a massive file of more than a hundred pages.

“That’s a lot.”

“I investigated just as thoroughly.”

Choi Minwoo nodded and began flipping rapidly through the pages. What he was reading was one man’s life.

Jin Taekyung’s twenty-seven years were contained in those hundred-odd pages.

Birthplace, background, how he had grown up—even account inquiry records provided by the bank. Nothing was missing.

Anything unusual or suspicious had been marked in bold, allowing Choi Minwoo to finish the entire file in under thirty minutes.

“What do you think, Butler Kim?”

“He’s clean.”

Butler Kim’s answer was definitive.

“He isn’t an illegal Awakener, nor did he approach you as part of some scheme.”

Choi Minwoo nodded. If Butler Kim said so, then it was so.

Butler Kim had spent the past two weeks using every means available to investigate everything about Jin Taekyung. Every one of the hundred-odd pages on the table would have passed through his hands.

“So this was all a coincidence?”

“For now, yes.”

“Butler Kim.”

“Yes. Please go ahead.”

“Do you know the odds of reawakening?”

“I understand they’re around one percent.”

One in a hundred.

To an ordinary person, that might not sound impossibly rare. But those hundred people weren’t ordinary people. They were Hunters who had already beaten similar odds just to Awaken in the first place.

And even among them, only a chosen few were lucky enough to reawaken.

“Then what are the odds of an F-rank Hunter reawakening as a C-rank Hunter in one leap?”

Choi Minwoo didn’t wait for an answer.

“And what are the odds of a C-rank Hunter clearing a Gate of the same rank alone?”

“Alone, it would be impossible. He would have to be at least B-rank…”

“And yet there’s someone who can.”

“Could it be…?”

“Ten C-rank Gates and ten D-rank Gates. Across twenty raids, all I did was stand by with my arms crossed and watch. There was never any need for me to step in.”

His long fingers tapped the thick binder.

Everything about Jin Taekyung was written inside it, yet in another sense, it said nothing at all.

After a moment of silence, Butler Kim spoke.

“I’ll investigate him again.”

“No.”

Choi Minwoo shook his head.

“Keep poking at it and we’ll only make trouble for ourselves. I intend to keep him close and watch him.”

“Do you intend to recruit him into the Guild after all?”

“I should. If something smells fishy, I’ll dig into his background. If not…”

Choi Minwoo’s eyes gleamed.

“I’ll make him one of my people. Even if it takes Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage.[268]”

And in the next moment—

Jingle.

The doorbell rang as someone entered the café, and Choi Minwoo gave a quiet laugh.

Zhuge Liang—or rather, Jin Taekyung.

A signing bonus of 500 million won.[269]

A fixed monthly salary of 50 million won[270] and a seventy-percent settlement share.

[268] “Paying three personal visits” alludes to Liu Bei’s repeated visits to Zhuge Liang in *Romance of the Three Kingdoms* to recruit him as an adviser.

[269] 500 million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[270] 50 million won is about $36,000 or €32,000.

An officetel of roughly 132 square meters[271] and a sedan came as extras, while coverage under all four national insurance programs was a given. After reading through the contract, I had exactly one thought.

This is insane.

What kind of outrageous terms were these?

They were giving me a home, a car, and more money than I knew what to do with.

The average annual income of a C-rank Hunter was 200 million won,[272] including fixed pay and raid earnings.

And me?

The signing bonus alone is 500 million.[273]

These terms were normally reserved for B-rank Hunters or higher.

That meant they valued my skills that highly. It was also proof that I had found an employer with enough insight not to judge a Hunter by rank alone.

And he has the money to back it up.

I stared across the table at Team Leader Choi. As always, his expression gave nothing away, and his eyes were deep.

Team Leader Choi suddenly spoke.

“This is the third time.”

He had made me two offers before, and I had turned them both down. This was his roundabout way of telling me not to refuse him again.

“I’m sorry about that. There was a minor issue.”

“Have you resolved it?”

“Yes. For now, I think so.”

“Then there shouldn’t be any problem now.”

“…Of course.”

Even as I answered, doubt gnawed at me.

Was there really no problem now? Was it okay to leave things like this?

What the hell am I thinking?

I needed to get this over with before my thoughts wandered again.

“I’ll sign.”

I began signing with the fountain pen Team Leader Choi had handed me.

One page, two pages, three…

The contract was five pages long. All I had to do was write the three characters of my name on the last page, and it would be done.

At that moment, the question returned.

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[271] An officetel is a Korean mixed-use unit designed for both office and residential use. 132 square meters is about 1,420 square feet.

[272] 200 million won is about $140,000 or €130,000.

[273] 500 million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

Is this really okay?

The fountain pen that had moved without hesitation began to slow. One thought led to another.

What if it isn't? But isn't this exactly what I wanted?

It was.

This was what I had desperately dreamed of for seven years.

A massive salary and high social standing.

Becoming a son and older brother my family could be proud of, and giving them a comfortable life.

Becoming someone others envied and admired instead of ignored and looked down on.

I can have it all now.

I could spend the rest of my life enjoying all of it. Goodbye to my miserable old life. Goodbye to that shitty Murim.

Crack.

And goodbye to the fountain pen, too.

I relaxed my grip. Ink spilled from the shattered pen and soaked into the contract.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung. Let me ask you again."

Team Leader Choi pulled out a white handkerchief and wiped the ink that had splashed onto his chin.

Despite the sudden mess, he looked perfectly calm.

"That problem from last time. Have you really resolved it?"

"No."

The moment I answered, I felt a weight lift from my chest.

"If it's something I can help you with…"

"I appreciate the offer, but I have to handle this myself."

Team Leader Choi studied me with an odd look, then gave a quiet laugh.

"I didn't know signing a contract could be this difficult. I never expected to be turned down three times, either."

He sounded more amused by the situation than angry.

"When would be a good time for the fourth offer?"

He had probably meant it half as a joke, but my answer was serious.

"Tomorrow. Same time, same place."

"Tomorrow?"

"Yes. Tomorrow."

Only one day.

But for me, it would be a month, or perhaps several.

Team Leader Choi had no way of knowing that, and he furrowed his brow.

“I don’t much like jokes like that.”

“Neither do I. Not jokes like this.”

He had no idea what my words meant.

“I’ll be sure to see you.”

It was a vow to myself.

A vow that I would return alive.

And…

“Tomorrow, you’ll have to raise the contract terms even further.”

I left the café, leaving Team Leader Choi behind with his eyes wide.

“Phew.”

I took a deep breath and opened the capsule.

The sight of the sagging seat and VR headset made my heart pound. Even after coming this far, temptation kept rearing its head and whispering to me.

Don’t go back.

Forget everything and be satisfied with your life here.

Everyone you met in Murim was an NPC, and Murim is nothing more than a game.

Right. There had been a time when I thought that way.

But after wrestling with it, I realized that one way or another, I was going back.

I’d already reached my conclusion a long time ago.

On the night of the blizzard, I had gone back for Gong Yacheong.

I had brought along two young siblings who were nothing but baggage, and instead of using the reconnaissance squad as shields, I had fought Jopil and nearly died.

It probably started then.

That was when the three letters *NPC*, lodged in my mind, began to fade.

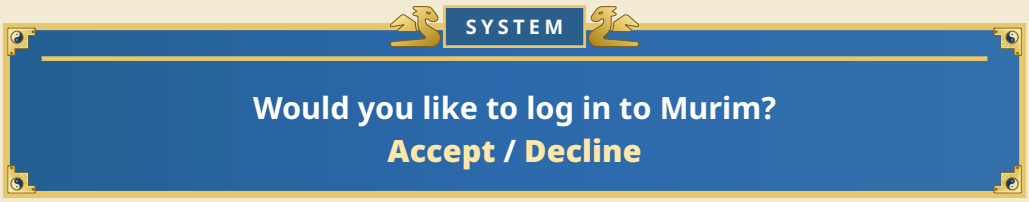
That was when I saw the two-character word for family in Jin Wikyung’s back as he told me to survive and turned away.[274]

“Fuck. My life really is a variety show.”

With a hollow, complaining laugh, I climbed into the capsule. The moment I put on the VR headset, a single line of text appeared in front of me.

Ding.

[274] In Korean writing, each syllable is written as a single character block; the word for “family” consists of two such blocks, contrasting with the three Roman letters in “NPC.”



“Yes.”

My consciousness faded. My vision went dark.

I logged in.

Chapter 55

This is driving me crazy.

Hyuk Mujin felt the world go yellow before his eyes.

Assassins disguised as disciples of minor sects. The Head Elder's betrayal. That alone was enough to make his head explode, but…

Why the hell did this guy collapse too?!

Jin Taekyung had passed out without warning. The reconnaissance squad members had taken turns slapping his cheeks and shaking him by the collar, but he still showed no sign of waking.

He's definitely still breathing.

It was enough to make a ghost weep. And with things as they were, Hyuk Mujin—the deputy squad leader—had ended up in charge of this enormous mess.

"You, and you."

Mujin singled out two of the reconnaissance squad members still standing there in a daze.

"Return to the main family at once and report what happened."

The Head Elder.

Mujin did not know why one of the family's most respected elders, a hero of the old Great Faction War, had devised such a dark scheme or what he hoped to gain from it.

But they had to prevent the worst from coming to pass.

"The rest of us are heading for the main force. Hurry!"

Mujin hoisted the unconscious Jin Taekyung onto his back.

After running for roughly two hours, the world went yellow before his eyes again—this time for a different reason.

I'm going to die.

It had only been a few days since Jopil's brutal palm strike had left him with internal injuries. He had boasted to Jin Taekyung that he was almost fully recovered, but in truth, he needed at least two solid weeks of rest.

"Huff… huff."

He was soaked through, and his legs were trembling.

He would have fallen behind even if he had only been trying to keep up. With the solidly built Jin Taekyung on his back, he was practically dying.

Ah, Mother. Father.

Now he was even hallucinating his parents—who were alive and well—beckoning to him. The woman standing beside them had a face he often saw in the temple hall.

Guanyin Bodhisattva?[275]

"Child. You have suffered enough. You may rest now."

Her benevolent smile slowly put Mujin's heart at ease.

Yeah. I've done enough. The squad leader drops like a rock when it matters most, and these bastards won't even offer to carry him for me, whether I drop dead or not.

Fuck it. Whatever.

Mujin was just about to let go when—

"Whew… haaah."

Warm breath slipped into his ear. He knew who it was without turning around. Tears of relief stung Hyuk's eyes.

"Captain!"

Jin Taekyung grinned and whispered,

"Candy in your ear."[276]

Clang! Clang!

"Kill them! Kill them!"

"Graaah!"

Blood sprayed and screams rang out on every side. A blood-soaked martial artist crawled on all fours between the corpses.

His still-youthful face was stained with pain and terror.

"Hnnh… hhhk…"

He tried to hold it back, but the sobs kept breaking free. He had spent ten years gritting his teeth and honing his martial arts, yet none of it had helped him on this blood-soaked battlefield.

The senior he had relied on was dead. So was the fellow disciple who had been like a brother. Weapons had poured in from every direction, splitting open bellies and hacking limbs apart.

"Mother… Mother…"

He called for her over and over until his face suddenly went rigid.

Shunk—!

A spearhead protruded from his chest.

His eyes flew wide for an instant, then the light faded from them. A wandering martial artist with a bandit's beard pulled his rusty spear free and grinned.

"What's a brat doing here?"

---

[275] Guanyin, known as Gwaneum in Korea, is the bodhisattva of compassion in East Asian Buddhism.

[276] "Candy in your ear" and "Was it sweet as a dream?" reference lyrics from the Korean pop song "My Ear's Candy."

But even a wandering martial artist who had survived countless brushes with death could not dodge the blade that came flying at him a moment later.

Slice—

A silver line flashed, and the wandering martial artist's head shot into the air.

A wandering martial artist killed a martial artist. Another martial artist killed the wandering martial artist.

Nameless men killed and died on every side, over and over.

That was what a battlefield was.

Yes. This was what it was like.

The Head Elder gazed over the battlefield, lost in memory.

Eight Spring Gorge. A battleground that had earned a single line in the history of the Great Faction War decades ago. How many people had died in that narrow gorge?

I was young then, too.

His body had been strong, and his heart had burned hot. Back then, the embarrassing word *chivalry* had still meant so much to him.

But the Great Faction War had changed the Head Elder. He had grown weary of the endless fighting and afraid of death.

What good is a chivalrous warrior? Die, and you're nothing but a ghost.

That realization had been a form of enlightenment. In the end, he had survived and become a hero. After long years of patient endurance, he had finally reached this point.

Now it was time to reap the fruit.

The Head Elder turned his shrewd old eyes toward the man standing beside him.

What a waste. Such a waste.

Jin Wikyung was a remarkable talent. He was young, highly accomplished in martial arts, and above all, possessed the dignity and judgment a leader needed. He sometimes allowed sentiment to sway him, but perhaps that was also why he was so deeply respected within the family.

He is more than capable of restoring this family.

If Jin Wikyung became the Family Head, and if his two younger brothers—each already distinguishing himself—stood firmly behind him…

The Head Elder caught himself and let out a short laugh.

What a ridiculous thing to be thinking after coming this far. Besides, Jin Taekyung was probably already dead, reduced to a lonely ghost.

"I've grown old."

Jin Wikyung reacted to the quiet mutter.

"Did you say something?"

“Nothing of importance. Old men tend to talk to themselves. More importantly, how does the battle look to you, Lesser Family Head?”

“It is going in our favor, but…”

Jin Wikyung’s expression darkened slightly. They held the advantage in troop quality and terrain, but their casualties continued to mount.

There was no way he could watch members of his family die and feel at ease.

“Lesser Family Head. I understand how you feel, but do not act rashly.”

The Head Elder’s warning was stern.

“A leader must know when to step forward. The longer the battle drags on, the more impatient the enemy will become. That is the moment we must seize.”

“The Mount Heng Sword Sect will soon throw its full strength at us.”

“They’ll put their Peak masters at the front. Their Sect Leader, Lee Cheonbaek, may even come himself.”

“Then everything will be decided.”

The Head Elder nodded.

“If you, Wipeng, and I hold off the enemy commanders while arrows rain down from the cliffs, their morale will collapse.”

“It’s a shame we can’t use fire. I resent the heavens.”

The narrow terrain of Eight Spring Gorge was perfect for a fire attack, but the heavy snowfall several days ago had left snowdrifts everywhere.

Yet even if the heavens had taken Jin Wikyung’s side, what he hoped for would never have happened.

The men drawing their bows atop the cliffs would obey the Head Elder’s command.

“I resent the heavens as well.”

The Head Elder meant it.

He had waited far too many years. He resented Heaven’s mandate for arriving only now.

“Candy in your ear.”[277]

“Captain!”

“Was it sweet as a dream?”[278]

“…Are you insane?”

[277] “Candy in your ear” and “Was it sweet as a dream?” reference lyrics from the Korean pop song “My Ear’s Candy.”

[278] “Candy in your ear” and “Was it sweet as a dream?” reference lyrics from the Korean pop song “My Ear’s Candy.”

The sight of Hyuk Mujin's ugly face filled me with relief. I felt the same way about the other reconnaissance squad members who crowded around after hearing I was awake.

"Captain's awake!"

"What happened? Are you all right?"

"Wasn't he dead?"

I'd have to deal with the bastard who had just said that later. I memorized his face and name, then grinned at everyone.

"Been a while. You guys been well?"

"Huh?"

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"Did he hit his head?"

"His head—check his head!"

Exactly the reaction I'd expected.

Still, it was a greeting I'd genuinely wanted to give them at least once.

…Not that they didn't treat me like a lunatic afterward.

"Anyway, that's enough greeting. How long was I out?"

Mujin sank to the ground with a thud and answered.

"Definitely more than an hour, but probably a little under two."

I'd spent two weeks in reality, so the timing roughly lined up. I nodded and moved on to my next question.

"Was I breathing?"

"Why are you asking that all of a sudden? Seriously."

"We don't have time. Just answer."

"You were breathing, so you woke up. Otherwise, you'd be dead."

Fair enough.

Apparently, logging in or out left my body on the other side in a state of suspended animation.

If I'd logged out before dealing with the assassins, there wouldn't have been a body left for me to return to.

I'd think about that later.

There was a more urgent problem.

"The main force?"

"We were already heading toward them. I split off two men and sent them back to the family."

"Good. How much farther?"

"At least another two hours."

"Two hours…"

"Uh, Captain. I'm sorry to say this, but… I think we have to consider the worst-case scenario."

Mujin and every member of the reconnaissance squad fell silent. Nobody had to ask what the worst-case scenario meant.

I've thought about it too.

According to what Gwak Jun had said just before he died, this betrayal had been meticulously planned for a long time.

But the plan had exactly one flaw.

Me.

The Head Elder had underestimated me.

No—maybe in a way, he had overestimated me. He'd sent dozens of First Rate masters just to kill me.

Even that hadn't been enough. I had survived.

He made a mistake.

On top of that, when Gwak Jun first revealed his true colors, he'd said they needed to get moving soon if they wanted to arrive on time.

Which meant…

"It's not too late."

I met each squad member's eyes and spoke firmly.

"Don't think about the worst-case scenario. No matter what it takes, I'll change that outcome."

"Captain…"

"So, Mujin."

I gave Mujin's choked-up face a good-natured smile.

"Get up. Now."

"I'm dying here."

"Want to get beaten to death instead?"

"…"

"Run even one more step in the time we've got. Don't you know marathon spirit?"

"I don't."

Ah. Right. This was Murim.

"Anyway, get up. Another hour will do it."

Mujin grabbed his trembling legs and forced himself upright, then cocked his head.

"An hour?"

"Yeah. An hour."

"I already told you. Even at full speed, it'll take two hours."

"Exactly. An hour."

"What are you even talking about…?"

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

Mujin blinked at me with the guileless eyes of an ox. I smiled even brighter.

"You ever heard of grit?"

I didn't care whether it should take two hours or four.

We were getting there in one hour. Period.

"Run like hell. That'll do it."

"Huk."

Every face in the reconnaissance squad went deathly pale.

"We've been blocked."

"Casualties are mounting. Sect Leader, please take action."

Even as the reports continued, Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek, Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, did not open his eyes.

I was too hasty.

The war had started in a rush, and the preparations had been just as thin. Provisions were burning down fast, morale was dropping, and deserters were popping up one after another.

They read us completely.

Rage over his son's death and impatience with the situation had clouded his judgment. He had ignored his subordinates' advice and chosen the fastest route.

And so he had encountered the Jin Family of Taiyuan in a narrow gorge whose very name had been unfamiliar to him: Eight Spring Gorge.

"Sect Leader!"

At his subordinate's shout, Lee Cheonbaek slowly opened his eyes.

The formidable eyesight of a Peak master pierced the battlefield.

"Gaaah!"

"Wipe them out! They're nothing but rabble!"

Well over a thousand of his men were trapped at the narrow entrance, unable to advance. The wandering martial artists and mounted bandits he had placed at the front had numbers, but individually, they were inferior even to the Jin Family's rank-and-file warriors.

Sword fodder, at best.

Just as he clicked his tongue inwardly, several dozen wandering martial artists began peeling away from the front line. The middle-aged wanderer leading them shouted at the top of his lungs.

“This is a dog’s death! Brothers of the Blood Rain Group, fall back!”

Those became the middle-aged wandering martial artist’s last words.

Whoosh—

A light breeze.

That was all the wanderer felt.

He did not know that Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek had already brushed past him. He did not know that the wandering martial artists under him had frozen in terror.

He only thought, all of a sudden, that his neck felt hot.

“Uh…”

His cleanly severed head dropped with a dull thunk. The headless body staggered a few more steps, then went down like a rotten old tree.

“Blood Rain Group, was it?”

Lee Cheonbaek pointed his sword at the frozen wanderers. Not a single drop of blood stained the blade.

“Go back.”

A Peak master’s killing intent shot into them like a blade. The wandering martial artists charged toward the front even faster than they had come.

They had decided that fighting at the front beat throwing themselves at the Peak master in front of them.

“Rat bastards.”

Lee Cheonbaek went after them. His burning gaze was aimed somewhere ahead, where the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s command had to be.

“The Sect Leader is taking the lead!”

“Everyone, charge! Wipe out the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

As Lee Cheonbaek stepped forward, the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s core forces followed.

Three Peak masters and dozens of First Rate masters surged toward the front.

Chapter 56

The Head Elder was the first to notice Lee Cheonbaek's arrival.

The leader himself has entered the fray.

The fierce wave of qi blasting across the gorge, and the killing intent rolling with it, made that obvious even without seeing him.

Sure enough—

"You bastards!"

Lee Cheonbaek appeared with a thunderous roar. His half-gray hair whipped around like a mane, and his eyes burned red.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect's core forces arrived on his heels—First Rate martial artists and three Peak masters!

"Wipe out those Jin Family of Taiyuan bastards!"

"The Sect Leader is here! The Sect Leader has come!"

"Waaaah!"

The cheers rekindled their fading will to fight. Lee Cheonbaek surged down the path that had opened before him.

"Kill those treacherous Jin Family of Taiyuan bastards!"

Jin Wikyung was not about to stand by and watch.

"The time has come."

The Head Elder answered.

"I agree."

In truth, he had not welcomed Lee Cheonbaek's arrival. A certain amount of attrition would have made the cleanup easier.

But neither the Jin Family of Taiyuan nor the Mount Heng Sword Sect had suffered significant losses yet.

It doesn't matter. They'll be making their move anyway.

The two great powers claimed to rule Shanxi, but compared to *them*, they were insignificant.

Even at the height of its power, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been treated as nothing more than a martial family from the frontier. How could it possibly stand against them?

A mere martial family…

The Head Elder swallowed a bitter smile and drew his sword.

Shing.

For many years, he had carried two swords—one in his heart and one at his waist.

There was no need for further words.

"I'll handle Lee Cheonbaek."

"Please do."

Who was Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek? The man who had founded the Mount Heng Sword Sect with nothing but a single sword, and who now meant to become the ruler of an entire city. Enemy or not, there was no denying he was a Peak martial artist of the highest caliber.

I want to fight him.

But Jin Wikyung forced down the heat in his blood.

This battle would decide the fate of his family. He had to set aside his fighting spirit.

"Wipeng."

"Yes."

Wipeng had already drawn his sharp, narrow sword and taken his place at Jin Wikyung's side.

"You and I will handle the rest."

"As you command."

There was not a trace of hesitation in his answer. Jin Wikyung smiled faintly and drew his own sword—the treasured blade passed down through generations of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

It was the only thing left behind by the father who had vanished one day without a trace.

> I'm going to travel around the Central Plains for a while.
> Use this in the meantime.

Remembering the letter stuffed carelessly into the scabbard made Jin Wikyung's blood boil all over again.

Travel around the Central Plains, my ass. You spent your whole life having fun.

He had no idea where that so-called Family Head was or what he was doing, and his second brother, thousands of li[279] away, had probably only just received the letter.

I have to protect them.

Martial artists, maids, servants, children.

Jin Wikyung was the Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan now. No one else.

Whether they lived or died was a burden he alone had to bear.

We will win.

Jin Wikyung's eyes flared wide. He raised his sword and unleashed an azure dragon's roar.

"Don't let a single one of them live!"

[279] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 meters (0.311 miles).

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

The Jin Family's masters kicked off the ground and soared into the air. At the signal, a single fire arrow rose high behind them.

That was when dozens of figures stood up along the cliffs.

"Fire!"

Beneath a sudden rain of arrows, the clash between the masters who would decide the course of the battle began.

Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek was a born martial artist.

Blessed with an innate talent for martial arts and the instincts of a beast, he had cut down his enemies and fulfilled his ambitions one after another.

He had founded the Mount Heng Sword Sect, then strengthened it by absorbing the surrounding factions one by one. His aim was to lay the foundation for a great family that would one day be recognized even in the Central Plains.

"Sect Leader! The Young Master…"

Then, one day, his second son came home a corpse.

He had not died in a fair duel. Deadly poison had killed him, blood pouring from all seven orifices.[280]

Lee Cheonbaek swore an oath.

He would kill and burn everything connected to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

And now Jin Wikyung stood before him.

Flames blazed in Lee Cheonbaek's eyes.

"You bastard—!"

He charged like a beast. His sword, imbued with one jiazi[281] of internal energy, shone milky white.

With this much power, it could cut through any armor or divine weapon.

That bastard dies here!

Certain of his victory, Lee Cheonbaek was about to swing when—

"Oho. Sword Energy?"

A quiet voice came from behind him.

Lee Cheonbaek's heart sank.

How?

He had given up his back far too easily. His response was lightning-fast. Gripping his sword in reverse, he stabbed behind him.

Whoosh.

[280] The seven orifices are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

[281] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

The blade pierced empty air, but the attack bought him time. Only then did he get a look at his opponent.

A beard hung down to the man's chest, and a relaxed smile played at the corners of his mouth.

He was a white-haired old man.

Lee Cheonbaek recognized him at once.

"Blade of Flowers?"

The Head Elder nodded.

"I haven't heard that name in a long time. And you must be Lee Cheonbaek."

"That's right."

Even as he answered, a chill ran down Lee Cheonbaek's spine.

He did not dare look for Jin Wikyung or check how the battle was unfolding. If he took his eyes off the old man, he felt as though his head would come off at once.

Coincidence? No.

It was true that the sight of Jin Wikyung had driven him into a frenzy. It was also true that impatience had gotten the better of him.

But Lee Cheonbaek was a Peak master.

A Peak master who had reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy.

There could only be one answer.

A master!

Whether by a full form or half a form, the old man before him stood above Lee Cheonbaek.

Lee Cheonbaek tightened his grip on his beloved sword.

"I've heard much of your reputation."

"Reputation? I'm nothing more than an old man put out to pasture."

"Then why didn't you stay there?"

"You're still young, so there's a lot you don't understand. The older you get, the more important it is to move around once in a while."

Lee Cheonbaek ground his teeth at the Head Elder's sly manner.

Damn old man.

He had been watching the Jin Family of Taiyuan for a long time.

He knew there was a faction centered around the Head Elder that opposed the Family Head. He had even privately hoped the family would split from within.

Instead, the exact opposite had happened.

So when an outside enemy invades, they unite as one?

Lee Cheonbaek stared at the Head Elder with heavy eyes, then opened his mouth.

"How strong are you?"

"As strong as you believe me to be."

“Word games.”

“I was thirty when they called me Blade of Flowers.”

The Head Elder had already been a Peak martial artist at thirty.

Now he was seventy. How much had his martial arts changed since then?

After a moment’s thought, Lee Cheonbaek gave a wry laugh.

I’ve grown old too.

Blood Wolf Sword.

In his youth, Lee Cheonbaek had been unstoppable. Without an exceptional martial art or a respectable master, he had carved his way through everything on his own.

Even against an opponent a level above him, he never backed down. He charged like a wolf and tore out their throats.

I lived half my life that way…

At some point, people had started calling him Sect Leader instead of Blood Wolf Sword.

Blood relatives, subordinates, wealth.

The things he had to protect had piled up like a mountain.

He spent less time training and more time handling affairs. When the moment came to act, he stopped to think instead.

Just as he was doing now.

“Why are you laughing?”

Lee Cheonbaek answered the Head Elder’s question.

“I’m laughing because I find myself pathetic.”

“You’re afraid of me.”

Lee Cheonbaek nodded in silence.

“Were you afraid of death?”

“For a very brief moment.”

“And now?”

“I’m going to kill you.”

“Someone of your level can’t manage that.”

“You have to measure them to know which is longer, don’t you?”

“That’s what the short ones always say. They never realize that even after you measure, the result doesn’t change.”

“You have a sharp tongue.”

“My tongue isn’t the only thing that’s sharp.”

The Head Elder lowered his sword.

It looked like an ordinary blue-steel sword, but the moment it entered his hand, it began to give off a vicious killing edge.

“Come at me first.”

Lee Cheonbaek did not refuse.

His blade drew in one jiazi[282] of internal energy, raising a shimmering haze of light.

The level of injuring others with Sword Energy—a realm countless martial artists dreamed of reaching.

Tssss.

The instant the Sword Energy rose three chi[283]—about ten centimeters—Lee Cheonbaek shot forward.

A unique martial art, perfected through countless real battles, unfolded from his fingertips.

Whoosh! Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Boom!

Sword Energy slashed in every direction. Screams erupted amid the mounds of dirt blasted into the air.

“Graaagh!”

They were the cries of martial artists caught in the gap.

Every voice belonged to a young man.

A red warning light went on in Lee Cheonbaek’s mind.

Behind!

He spun and swung in the same motion.

He saw a white beard fluttering in the wind.

And the sword in the old man’s hand.

Boom!

Kh.

The thunderous impact sent Lee Cheonbaek reeling backward. He was not even given time to feel the pain in his wrist.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Every time the two swords met, thunder and lightning rolled.

Sword Energy streamed from their blades, smashing the ground and tearing through the air.

Whoosh!

“What in the world is that…?”

The martial artists on both sides forgot their own battles. They could only stare, dumbstruck, at the incredible life-and-death duel.

At that moment, every one of them was thinking the same thing.

---

[282] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[283] One chi is about 3.03 centimeters (1.19 inches); three chi are about 9.1 centimeters (3.6 inches), rounded to ten centimeters in the source.

Are those two really human beings like us?

The ceaseless thunder. A display of Sword Energy so dazzling that merely watching it left them spellbound.

The movements of the two men at its center were faster and stronger than anyone they had ever seen.

Someone murmured as if groaning.

“So this is a Peak master…”

To their eyes, either man could have won.

But the superiority in strength was obvious.

After some three hundred exchanges, the Head Elder’s swordplay changed.

Whoosh—slice!

“Ghk.”

Lee Cheonbaek bit down on his lip.

Blood streamed from the forearm the Head Elder’s sword had raked.

The strength drained from his sword hand.

Of all things.

He immediately shifted the sword to his other hand, but he was right-handed by nature.

Even fighting at full strength might not have been enough. Now that his sword arm was injured, the outcome was all but decided.

Boom!

Crack.

A single blow snapped his wrist.

His Sword Energy, weakened by the severe drain on his internal energy, could no longer stand against the Head Elder.

But Lee Cheonbaek did not give up.

Not yet. It isn’t over yet.

He had taken worse injuries than this, plenty of times.

Drawing on the strength in his arm, waist, and legs, Lee Cheonbaek swung his sword.

No—he tried to.

Slash!

This time, it was the knee.

The severed tendons gave way, and Lee Cheonbaek’s knee buckled against his will.

His sword carved uselessly through empty air.

Shhk. Shhk-shhk-shhk.

His side. His shoulder. His chest.

Lightning stabbed and sliced through his entire body. The fierce Sword Energy did more than cut flesh and bone—it churned his insides.

"Bleeegh!"

Lee Cheonbaek vomited blood mixed with pieces of his organs and looked up at the Head Elder through clouded eyes.

The old man's face was impassive.

There was no thrill at having defeated his opponent, nor any joy at the war's end.

To him, this was nothing more than the natural outcome.

"Cough… So Shanxi's Number One was standing right in front of me."

"If you're not Number One Under Heaven, you're nothing more than a martial brute from the frontier. Neither you nor I are made for such heights."

"Tell me what you want. I'll give you my neck. I'll make my men surrender, and I'll seal the sect for ten years—or a hundred. So…"

"No. What I want is annihilation. Complete annihilation, without a single blade of grass left standing."

"Why…!"

"Don't ask me that. If you had won, it would have been our family facing annihilation."

Lee Cheonbaek glared at the Head Elder with bloodshot eyes.

He wanted to snap that wrinkled neck then and there.

But grievously wounded as he was, all he could do was force out his voice.

"Jin Family of Taiyuan. You started this, didn't you? You killed that boy—my son!"

"Ah, Lee Seogeun. Yes. That child was where it all began."

A sardonic smile touched the Head Elder's lips.

Even the master of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, one of the two powers that divided Shanxi between them, had failed to notice *their* intervention.

Even now, with death staring him in the face.

When you meet Yama,[284] ask him who killed Lee Seogeun.

The Sound Transmission burrowed into Lee Cheonbaek's ear, and his eyes flared wide.

"What does that mean…?"

It was a thoroughly impulsive act.

Perhaps pity for Lee Cheonbaek, who was about to die knowing nothing.

Or perhaps it was nothing more than an old man's whim.

Consider it fare for the road to the afterlife. Think it over on your long journey.

The Head Elder raised his sword.

The light of the setting sun beyond the winter ridge splintered across the blade.

[284] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld.

With this…

With the death of the giant called Lee Cheonbaek, the Mount Heng Sword Sect would collapse.

Those who resisted would die. Those who surrendered would be taken prisoner.

One war would end…

And a new war would begin the moment everyone was drunk on victory.

It's over.

At last, the Head Elder's sword moved.

Screeeech—!

A sharp sound tore through the air.

Sensing his end, Lee Cheonbaek closed his eyes.

The blade, wrapped in blue Sword Energy, traced a beautiful arc.

Slice.

But both the sound that had come first and the direction of the sword were not what Lee Cheonbaek had expected.

A spear had come flying at the Head Elder's back out of nowhere, and he split it apart with Sword Energy.

The old man roared in fury.

"Who the hell are you?"

The answer came an instant later.

"It's me, you fucking bastard!"

The Head Elder saw the face of a young man standing tall on a low hill, and groaned.

"Jin Taekyung?"

Chapter 57

"Faster! Go faster!"

"Huff… huff!"

We ran like mad. Hyuk Mujin was panting like he was about to drop dead, but he didn't. Whenever he started to slow down, I pressed the spearhead against his back, and he took off like Red Hare.[285]

Then the sounds began to reach us.

Screams. Steel clashing against steel…

Good. The battle wasn't over yet.

Relief hit me, and my heart hammered at the same time. The fighting was still going on, but I still hadn't confirmed whether Jin Wikyung was alive or dead.

What if he died because we were a minute—or even a second—too late?

If that happens…

Crack.

My grip tightened around the spear before I realized it. I drew internal energy from my dantian and sent it flowing into both legs.

"C-Captain!"

I kept running, leaving the reconnaissance squad's voices fading behind me. The countless tracks left by the main force and the growing din of the battlefield showed me the way.

Stay alive. Stay alive. Please, stay—

There!

Below a low hill, less than two hundred meters[286] away, countless martial artists were locked in a bloody struggle, killing and being killed.

"Die!"

"Gaaah!"

Corpses and blood—and more corpses, more blood!

The sight before me was so brutal that it left me speechless.

If my years as a Hunter hadn't hardened me to this sort of thing, I probably would have stood there stunned for a long time.

Jin Wikyung! Where is Jin Wikyung?

But someone else caught my eye first.

White hair, unmistakable even from this distance.

The Head Elder!

He stood in front of someone, sword in hand.

---

[285] Red Hare is the legendary warhorse of Lü Bu in *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*.

[286] Two hundred meters is about 656 ft.

The Head Elder's back blocked most of my view, but the man kneeling in front of him was huge and held a sword of his own.

A big man with a sword?

Only one person came to mind.

Jin Wikyung. If I wanted to save him, I had to act now.

Open Inventory.

My Murim Inventory was packed with all kinds of things.

The spear I pulled out was one of them, with a wooden shaft and a steel head.

Equip Weapon.

Spear in hand, I took several steps back.

Two hundred meters.[287] An impossibly long distance—especially if I was trying to hit someone with a thrown spear.

But I had to do it.

No reason I can't.

Strength, Stamina, Agility.

I pushed the stats I'd built up traveling between Murim and reality to their limits.

With internal energy in my arm, I could send the spear farther and harder.

"Hup."

I held my breath and stepped forward. The first step was slow, the final step heavy. My arm snapped out like a whip, and the spear shot from my fingertips.

Fwoooosh!

The throw was faster and more accurate than I'd expected. It looked ready to punch straight through the Head Elder's back.

But then…

Shhk.

What the hell was that?

Blue light flashed, and the spear split cleanly in two from the tip of the spearhead to the end of the shaft.

I couldn't tell whether I'd thrown a spear or a birthday cake.

"Who the hell are you?"

The old man had quite a set of lungs.

"It's me, you son of a bitch!"

That was probably the first time in the Head Elder's life anyone had cursed him like that.

To make matters worse, he and I belonged to the same family in Murim. Going by the family tree, the difference in seniority between us was roughly that of an archaeopteryx and a chick.

---

[287] Two hundred meters is about 656 ft.

That alone was plenty of reason for him to be stunned, but I still had one finishing blow left.

"The Head Elder is—!"

My voice, loaded with internal energy, thundered across the battlefield. Even I was startled by how loud it was. I could only imagine what it sounded like to everyone else.

I stared at his cold, frozen face in the distance and shouted with all my might.

"A traitor!"

Jin Wikyung heard the voice immediately after bringing down all three Peak masters of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

No, it wasn't just him. Everyone on the battlefield heard the shout.

"Who the hell are you?"

"It's me, you son of a bitch!"

Cursing?

That was common enough on a battlefield. But it was a different matter when the target was the Head Elder and the young man who had appeared out of nowhere to hurl such abuse at him was Jin Taekyung.

"Isn't that… isn't that the Third Young Master?"

"What? That's Jin Taekyung? But why?"

"What's going on?"

Jin Wikyung was wondering the same thing.

What in the world is happening?

His youngest brother, who should have been in the rear, had appeared on the battlefield. That alone was bewildering enough, but now he was hurling unspeakable abuse at one of the family's most senior elders.

Wipeng, standing beside him, muttered, "He's completely lost his mind."

Jin Wikyung was about to nod without thinking when—

"The Head Elder is—!"

An even bigger bomb dropped.

"A traitor!"

An icy silence fell over the battlefield. Even the sporadic clash of weapons came to an abrupt stop.

Everyone stared blankly at Jin Taekyung.

What kind of bullshit is this?

Betrayal? The Head Elder?

Is he drunk? The Third Young Master must be slipping back into his old habits.

The martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan naturally thought so, and those of the Mount Heng Sword Sect were no different.

Even the senior members who had recently begun to think better of Jin Taekyung gaped at him.

"What a lunatic."

"Does he have any idea who the Old Master is?"

If anyone deserved the most credit for this war, it was undoubtedly the Head Elder.

He had helped Jin Wikyung unite the family's forces, and in today's battle, he had defeated Lee Cheonbaek.

Even setting aside his contributions to the war, Jin Taekyung's claim could only sound absurd.

Who was the Head Elder?

He was a master of the previous generation whose title, the Blade of Flowers, was renowned even across the Central Plains. He was a symbol of righteousness who had struck down countless fiends during the Great Faction War.

Every martial artist in Shanxi held some measure of respect for him.

"That man? A son of a bitch? A traitor?"

"Good heavens. That boy is smearing shit over the Jin Family of Taiyuan's three-hundred-year history."

The Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect—everyone present seemed to share the same thought.

With at least one exception.

The Head Elder. Betrayal.

The moment Jin Wikyung heard his youngest brother's words, he felt all the blood in his body run cold.

The vague sense that something was wrong had finally taken shape.

Lee Seogeun's death was where it began.

He had died after being poisoned with a lethal toxin. The Mount Heng Sword Sect had named the Jin Family of Taiyuan as the culprit, sparking the war.

But the most important question had been left unanswered.

Who was the killer?

Even now, with the war nearing its end, the culprit hiding behind it all had never been identified. No—precisely because the war was nearing its end, no one cared about the killer's identity anymore.

Survival of the fittest. The strong would survive and claim everything.

This war... was wrong from the very beginning.

Lee Seogeun's death.

The unnaturally rapid spread of the rumors.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had declared war, and the Jin Family of Taiyuan had responded. That was how the fighting had begun in earnest.

And the Head Elder was there.

The Head Elder, who had shut himself away from the world, had emerged immediately after news of Lee Seogeun's poisoning reached the family. His role within the family had been enormous.

A respected martial artist. A revered elder of the family.

Without the Head Elder's active support, the Jin Family of Taiyuan might have split in two.

We made it this far because of his help.

Then Jin Wikyung turned the thought around.

We made it this far because this was exactly what the Head Elder wanted.

In a moment too brief to even call an instant, Jin Wikyung reached his conclusion and spoke.

"Wipeng."

"Your orders."

"Cut down the First Elder."

"What?"

The stooped, emaciated old man—the First Elder—stared wide-eyed.

The senior members nearby were equally shocked.

"L-Lesser Family Head!"

"What is the meaning of this…?"

But Wipeng did not hesitate. Before anyone could react, his sword was already flying toward the First Elder's chest.

Clang-clang-clang!

Two swords suddenly cut in and knocked Wipeng's blade aside.

Their wielders were two enormously tall, fat old men.

They were the Second and Third Elders, who, together with the First Elder, called themselves the Head Elder's hands and feet.

Wipeng's brow twitched when he saw the faint Sword Energy clinging to their blades.

"You were hiding your martial arts."

The First Elder answered with a punch.

Boom!

The profound internal energy he had accumulated over his long life sent Wipeng flying. Then the First Elder straightened his stooped back.

The entire field froze at the emergence of yet another Peak master, one who had spent his life hidden in the Head Elder's shadow.

“First Elder, what… what is this?”

“Then could it be…?”

Betrayal.

The word stamped itself into everyone’s mind.

“That’s impossible!”

The White Tiger Hall Leader let out a shrill shout. If the Elders were the Head Elder’s hands and feet, then he had served faithfully as the First Elder’s.

“Elder, Lesser Family Head. There seems to have been some misunderstanding…”

But he never finished.

The First Elder jerked his chin, and the Second Elder moved with blinding speed, severing the White Tiger Hall Leader’s neck.

Shhk. Thud.

Jin Wikyung and the First Elder locked eyes across the space between them.

“You recruited the White Tiger Hall Leader too?”

“He was loud. That was all. The others were no different.”

Jin Wikyung’s guess had been half right and half wrong.

The Elders had betrayed them, but the senior members of the Elders’ faction had not.

“Then why… Ah!”

“Sharp. I’ll give you that.”

The First Elder drew a dark, grimy bamboo tube from inside his robes. The fuse was already burning, and almost nothing remained.

“How could we share such an important secret with men like them? Their job was done once they’d thrown the family into confusion. It made things easier if they had no idea what was happening outside.”

Jin Wikyung screamed, “Stop him!”

“You’re too late.”

The First Elder was right.

The moment the fuse burned to its end, something burst, and a red flame shot high into the sky.

Fwish—boom!

It was a signal.

The martial artists of the small and mid-sized sects collectively known as the Five Gates of Shanxi changed in an instant—the Samdo Sect, an alliance of three sects; the saber-focused Byeokdo Sect; and the Gunggui Sect, which had been raining arrows down from the cliffs without pause.

“Kill everyone in your path!”

“No exceptions! Wipe them all out!”

They were no longer the clumsy Third Rate martial artists they had seemed to be. Killing intent flowed from their eyes, and their sword paths were sharp.

This wasn't something they prepared overnight.

Jin Wikyung's expression hardened.

Boom!

The Head Elder looked up at the sky. Before the red flame had even faded, thunderous shouts erupted from every direction.

Too fast. Far too fast.

The signal was supposed to be sent only after the Mount Heng Sword Sect had been annihilated. The Five Gates of Shanxi were a blade honed over decades. It had to be swung once and bring everything to a lightning-fast end.

All things have their proper flow.

The plan that had proceeded without a hitch was beginning to unravel.

As the Head Elder smiled bitterly, a voice reached his ears.

"So… it was you."

Lee Cheonbaek.

His voice was faint, but his eyes burned more fiercely than ever.

"You still have the strength to speak?"

"I'll tear you apart while you're still alive."

No sooner had Lee Cheonbaek finished speaking than blood gushed from his mouth. The Head Elder pressed one of his acupoints and murmured, "That would be inconvenient just yet. You still have something to do."

Lee Cheonbaek despaired.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had suffered heavy losses, but several hundred martial artists still remained. With its entire leadership destroyed, if the Sect Leader were now taken prisoner…

Kill me instead!

The anguished cry never left his mouth. The Head Elder pressed the Mute Acupoint, taking his voice. Then his hand brushed the Paralysis Acupoint, and Lee Cheonbaek's body went rigid.

He had become a living corpse with his eyes still open.

"You bastard! Get your hands off him!"

At the same moment, something shrieked through the air.

Fwoooosh!

The Head Elder did not panic. He swept his sword upward from below. Beyond the spear splitting in two along the line of his Sword Energy, Jin Taekyung was charging toward him at terrifying speed.

“Aaaaaah!”

“Captain! Please slow down a little!”

And with him came a dozen or so riffraff who had appeared from who knew where.

Chapter 58

The battlefield descended into chaos. At the signal, two hundred martial artists suddenly turned and swarmed in every direction like a pack of wolves.

“Kill them all!”

“Aaaaargh!”

They weren’t quite on the level of Gwak Jun and the assassins we’d fought earlier, but they radiated an aura like well-honed blades.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect. If the martial artists of both factions joined forces, we’d have a real chance—but right now, that looked difficult.

This is bad.

Worst case, I might have to pull Jin Wikyung out and run.

I was thinking that when the reconnaissance squad arrived behind me, breathing hard.

“Captain, maybe we can—huff!”

The moment they saw what was happening in front of them, their eyes nearly popped out. Hyuk Mujin, who came crawling up behind them, gaped as well.

“Bweeegh!”

“…So that was it.”

It must have been rough. After a fast, heavy burst of vomiting, Hyuk looked half-dead as he spoke.

“I think this is as far as I go.”

Anyone looking at him might have taken him for a wounded soldier who’d been stabbed while fighting bravely.

I gripped his shoulder hard.

“Mujin. You can do this.”

“No. I’m finished. I’ll only be a burden if I go.”

“A burden? You’re an excellent meat shie—”

“Excuse me?”

“Shield! You’re the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s shield!”

“I could have sworn you said meat shield.”

Ignoring Hyuk’s suspicious muttering, I hauled him to his feet. Right now, even a meat shield—no, a single extra hand—was precious.

Besides, apart from me, Hyuk was the strongest meat shield in the reconnaissance squad. Damn, it kept slipping out.

I deliberately lowered my voice.

“Our family is in danger, and you’re saying you want to run?”

If it had been me, I would have run.

“No, sir!”

A twenty-first-century office worker would have spat in your face and walked away even if you promised to file it as a workplace injury, but the reconnaissance squad was more loyal than I’d expected. Hyuk drew his sword, his face pale.

“Very well. If a martial artist has to die, he should die fighting.”

“That’s a fine resolve, but don’t die.”

“You just called me a meat shield.”

“You don’t trust me?”

“Yes.”

Hyuk’s answer was as sharp as a blade, and quiet laughter spread through the reconnaissance squad. The tension in my body, frozen by my first large-scale battle, eased a little.

I grinned and tightened my grip on my spear.

“Eyes wide, ears open. Follow my orders, and you’ll make it back alive.”

That was a vow I was making to myself. I would get these guys out alive somehow.

Please don’t die.

I didn’t know how this war would end, or who would live and who would die.

All I could do was give it everything I had.

“Let’s go.”

At that, we charged forward like a gale. We were an arrow with me at the tip, and our target had already been chosen.

The Head Elder.

Clear in the distance, I could see a white-haired old man. At his feet lay a fallen man surrounded by a pool of blood.

A ball of fire surged up from my gut.

“That’s my brother…”

I pulled a spear from where it had been driven into someone’s corpse like a gravestone. Then, in the next instant—

“Get your hands off him, you bastard!”

The spear shot straight ahead, devouring the hundreds of feet between us.

Someone in the reconnaissance squad let out a muffled cry.

“We got him!”

That was when the Head Elder’s sword moved.

Shuk.

A streak of light. The spear split in half and bounced away to either side.

Same result as before. But this time, we’d closed the distance considerably, so I saw it clearly.

The blue flash that surged along his blade for an instant.

Aura?

No. Why was that showing up here?

Aura.

A crystallization of mana that only an A-rank Hunter or higher could draw out.

Mana and internal energy were different only in name. Both were forms of qi. And since this was Murim, that made it Sword Energy.

Sword Energy.

Heh heh heh.

Fuck. Are you kidding me?

I'd known for a long time that the Head Elder was a master. I'd even been prepared to fight him if it came to that. The problem was that a Head Elder *who could use Sword Energy* hadn't been part of the plan.

This is a bit much.

I glanced aside and saw more than ten pairs of trembling eyes.

Hyuk Mujin's were practically undergoing an earthquake.

"C-Captain."

"Y-Yeah?"

"That just now… looked like Sword Energy."

"Yeah…"

"Can you use Sword Energy too?"

"If I could, I would've used it already. Even Jopil wasn't at that level."

"Right?"

"Right. But aren't you exhausted?"

"I feel like I'm going to throw up."

As if we'd agreed on it, we slowed down. We'd gone from the hundred-meter dash[288] to race walking, but it still felt like we were walking into a lion's jaws.

"Uh, Captain."

Hyuk spoke with every trace of color drained from his face. Judging by his complexion alone, he could have passed for a white man.

"Are you sure the Head Elder betrayed us?"

"I'm sure."

"Could it possibly be a misunderstanding—"

Before he could finish, three or four black-clad men charged at us with a shout.

[288] 100 meters is about 328 ft.

"Protect our lord!"

"For the Head Elder!"

Get a load of those lines. They'd work perfectly as a toast at a Jin Family of Taiyuan year-end party.

I cut down every last black-clad man charging us, then looked at Hyuk.

"Uh, what were you about to say?"

"…Nothing."

Having failed to win the argument in his own head, Hyuk hung his head with a grim expression.

But only for a moment. Step by step, the closer we drew to the Head Elder, the more desperately he searched for a way out.

"Why do people have to fight?"

Is this bastard aiming for the Nobel Peace Prize?

"You said earlier you'd fight and die. Like a martial artist."

"That was the worst-case scenario. Wouldn't it be better to settle this with a conversation?"

"Talking would be nice. But they sent assassins after us first."

"Oh."

"And I threw a spear."

"Ah."

"And I cursed while throwing it."

"Ah—ahhh."

By the time we were within about a hundred feet of the Head Elder, Hyuk's face looked like death. The other reconnaissance squad members didn't say anything, but I could see them trembling.

Of course, I wasn't much different. Just thinking about Sword Energy made my heart pound.

I'm well and truly screwed.

But I had no intention of running. If I had, I never would have come back in the first place. I would have been content with reality and simply kept living there.

I'd already come too far. There was only one path left.

"Stop."

Everyone halted as if they'd been waiting for it. Hyuk's face said he was hoping for a dramatic peace treaty, but I gripped my spear and stepped forward.

"W-Where are you going?"

"To fight. You wait here."

"Are you insane? We'd be better off waiting for the Lesser Family Head and attacking together—"

“See the person lying over there?”

“Y-Yes.”

“That’s my brother.”

Hyuk stared at me as though the sky had fallen, then let out a deep sigh.

“Then I’m coming with you.”

“What?”

“Even a meat shield like me should bump our odds up by a hair, shouldn’t it?”

This guy actually came up with some admirable thoughts.

I snorted a laugh and turned away.

“You trying to get yourself killed? I’m just going to feel him out and come back. Wait here.”

The Head Elder was now barely thirty feet away.

A distance either of us could cross in an instant.

A heavy silence pressed down on the space between us. In those few moments, my palms grew damp.

Phew.

But I wasn’t an easy mark either. At Level 30, when I was only Second Rate, I’d already defeated Jopil, a Peak master. And I’d continued to improve after returning to reality.

Now that I was Level 40, I could proudly call myself a master capable of holding his own in either reality or Murim.

No. I *was* a master.

If I keep as much distance between us as possible…

In a fight where a few centimeters[289] could decide life or death, a spear’s reach was a massive advantage.

I watched the Head Elder’s face and steadied my breathing.

This is doable.

I drew up my internal energy in a single burst and charged. Ten feet—the range where my spearhead could reach the Head Elder, while his sword couldn’t reach me.

Now!

I brought the spearhead down toward the crown of his head.

At the same time, the System notification I’d been waiting for rang out.

Ding.

[289] A few centimeters is roughly 1–2 in.

SYSTEM

| The effect of the Title **Gambler** is applied.
| **Strength** temporarily increases.
| **Agility** temporarily increases.
| **Stamina** temporarily...

The effect of the Gambler Title, which raised combat-related stats by ten percent in a one-on-one duel, seeped into every part of my body.

And on top of that—

Whoosh!

The increase in my stats accelerated the attack as well. The spearhead came down like a bolt of light, aimed at the crown of the Head Elder's head.

This is going in.

I was certain.

Even a monster like Jopil wouldn't have been able to dodge it. But the man I was facing wasn't Jopil.

He was the Head Elder.

Boom!

The spear shaft shuddered with a thunderous crash. The Head Elder had blocked the spear with a movement too fast for me to see, and now he smiled faintly.

"Not bad. Better than I expected."

Without even time to answer, I wrung out every last ounce of strength. The spear, loaded with tremendous force that even a decent master would have struggled to endure, crushed down on his sword.

Grrrkk.

With an ugly grinding sound, his sword slowly began to rise...

No. Wait.

It should be going down. Why is it coming up?

I'd put that much force into it, yet I was the one being pushed back. At my dumbfounded expression, the Head Elder's smile deepened.

"You tried, but did you think that would be enough?"

The next instant, every hair on my body stood on end.

Tssssss.

A blue haze bloomed along the blade.

Sword Energy.

Before I could even react, the spearhead that had been slowly getting pushed back was sliced off like tofu.

Shing.

Now it wasn't a spear but a staff. A long staff.

Sword Energy flashed again toward me as I backed away.

Shing.

The long staff became a short staff.

Shing.

"…"

Fuck. Even nunchucks would be longer than this.

I hurled the iron rod—no longer a spear or even a staff—at the Head Elder.

Shing.

"Do you intend to run?"

Run? What a hurtful thing to say.

I'd already thrown myself sideways the instant I released the rod. I grabbed the collar of the man lying facedown as though dead.

Got him!

My only goal from the start had been to rescue Jin Wikyung.

Now that I'd accomplished it, there was no reason to fight that monstrous old man. I clutched Jin Wikyung to me and launched myself away with all my strength.

Whoosh—boom!

The Sword Energy that came a beat later split the ground.

Hyuk Mujin and the reconnaissance squad surrounded us as we escaped the Head Elder's range by a hair.

"Protect the Captain!"

"Are you all right?"

I said nothing. I forgot that we had to flee from the Head Elder immediately. I even forgot that we were standing in the middle of a battlefield.

My mind was consumed by a single question.

Who is this man?

I'd definitely rescued Jin Wikyung. I was supposed to have rescued him…

So who was this macho-looking middle-aged man in my arms?

His face was covered in blade scars, and his eyes were bloodshot. In a trembling voice, I asked,

"Excuse me, but who are you…?"

At that moment, Hyuk Mujin let out a startled cry.

"Gah! Lee Cheonbaek!"

Lee Cheonbaek? The name rang a bell.

"You know him?"

"Of course I do!"

"Are you close?"

“What kind of bullshit is that? That’s Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek!”

“Blood Wolf Sword?”

“Yes! That Blood Wolf Sword…!”

“Cool alias. Sounds like a master.”

Hyuk tore at his hair and shouted,

“He’s the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect! Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek!”

“…!”

I scrambled backward.

This man was Lee Cheonbaek?

Cold sweat ran down my back.

He’s Lee Seogeun’s father.

He was the man who’d started a war because he thought I’d poisoned his son. He was also a cold-blooded killer who’d slaughtered adults and children alike in revenge.

As if rescuing the wrong man wasn’t bad enough, I nearly got stabbed for it.

But Lee Cheonbaek no longer seemed to have the strength left for that.

His whole body was covered in blood, and he couldn’t so much as twitch a hand. It looked like he’d suffered a serious Internal Injury or been subjected to a Pressure-Point Strike.

Still, at least it isn’t Jin Wikyung.

As if he’d read my mind, Hyuk asked,

“Then where is the Lesser Family Head?”

“I don’t know. And…”

I hurriedly yanked him back by the nape of his neck. A sword flew in and buried itself where Hyuk’s foot had been a moment earlier.

I’m really well and truly screwed.

I let out a deep sigh, then continued.

“You think that old man is going to let us go?”

The Head Elder burst into a hearty laugh.

“Ha ha ha! Have you ever seen such an insolent brat!”

“If I behave politely, will you let us go?”

“Don’t you think you’ve come too far for that?”

Tsssss.

Sword Energy surged up.

No more words were needed.

I pulled a spear stuck among the corpses. Then, with everyone’s eyes on me, I spoke.

“Encircling formation. Spread out.”

One of the oldest Hunter sayings went like this:

There are strong monsters, but no monster that can’t be taken down.

What made that possible was a raid.

Chapter 59

Shh-shh-shhk!

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng's battle against the three Elders raged like a storm.

Sword strikes crashed together from every direction, too fast and fierce for an ordinary martial artist to follow.

Krshhk.

Blocked.

The instant Wipeng realized it, he twisted aside. The Second Elder's sword grazed his hair as it thrust past.

The Second and Third Elders pressed him as though they were one.

"You bastards!"

Jin Wikyung charged with a roar, only for the First Elder to cut him off.

"Where are you rushing off to?"

Sword Energy shot upward, then plunged toward the crown of Jin Wikyung's head.

The blow threatened to split him in two. Jin Wikyung hurriedly raised his sword to block. Pale Sword Energy wreathed his blade as well.

Boom!

A figure staggered back through the cloud of dust kicked up by the thunderous impact. Jin Wikyung's face had gone pale. He spat out bloody phlegm.

What the hell kind of internal energy…

He had trained in exceptional martial arts and taken elixirs since he was a child, but this was a bad matchup. The First Elder was a vile old monster who had lived for more than one jiazi[290] while concealing his black heart.

Together with the Head Elder, he was a living witness who had fought his way through the Great Faction War.

"You goddamn old bastard."

The First Elder replied with a hearty laugh.

"Lesser Family Head, mind your dignity."

But the First Elder was not nearly as composed as he appeared.

His trembling blade and throbbing wrist were proof enough.

To think they were this strong.

Even in a street brawl, numbers mattered. How much more would they matter in a fight between masters? Yet Jin Wikyung and Wipeng were stronger than he had expected.

Or perhaps an old man's pride had led him to overestimate himself.

---

[290] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

How cruel. Truly cruel.

One jiazi[291]. He had accumulated profound internal energy over those sixty years, but even that could not halt the aging of his body.

If only I were ten years younger.

After a bitter jab at himself, the First Elder stepped toward Jin Wikyung.

The swords of his sworn younger brothers, the Second and Third Elders, grew fiercer still.

Shh-shh-shhk!

“Urgh!”

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng were gradually driven back. Having only just fought the Peak masters of the Mount Heng Sword Sect made their situation even worse.

Their vision began to swim. Small wounds multiplied across their bodies. Their hands and feet no longer moved as they wished.

We can’t keep this up.

Jin Wikyung’s expression darkened.

Fwoooosh!

The First Elder’s Sword Energy had been bearing down without pause when it abruptly changed course. In the next instant, a lightning-fast strike split its target.

Shhk.

Fwaaah!

A man staggered in a spray of blood. The sword he had aimed at the First Elder’s side had shattered beyond recognition, and blood poured from his chest like a waterfall.

The First Elder saw his face and clicked his tongue.

“Discipline Hall Master, you foolish friend. Did you want to die that badly?”

“F-First Elder…”

The Discipline Hall Master’s voice sounded ready to give out at any moment. Yet he neither fell nor stopped speaking.

“You have… violated the family’s laws.”

“Heh heh. And?”

“As the Discipline Hall Master of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, I command you. The guilty shall abolish their own martial arts and enter the Repentance Cave…”

Shhk.

The First Elder answered with his sword.

The Discipline Hall Master had a nature as unyielding as bamboo, but his martial arts were not particularly advanced. He could neither see nor evade the stroke that pierced his throat.

---

[291] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

Fire blazed in Jin Wikyung's eyes.

"You bastard!"

Jin Wikyung was not the only one enraged. The Discipline Hall Master's death set fire to the hearts of the Jin Family of Taiyuan's senior members.

"Discipline Hall Master!"

Before they were martial artists, they were human.

They had lived long enough to have much they had built, and much they had to protect. That was why they had feared it: a Peak master's prowess, thrown away on a dog's death.

But the Discipline Hall Master's dignified end brought emotions they had briefly forgotten boiling back to the surface.

Shame and anger.

"Strike down those traitors!"

"Show them the spirit of the Jin Family of Taiyuan!"

Those most ashamed of themselves were the first to charge. They were the senior members who had belonged to the so-called Council of Elders faction.

They could not forgive themselves for helping the traitors. Nor could they forgive the Elders who had betrayed both them and the family.

"Fools."

Shhk. Shhk. Shhk.

Every time the three Elders' swords flashed, another life was extinguished.

The difference in strength was clear. Even so, the Elders' wrinkled faces stiffened.

These bastards…!

Dozens of First Rate masters surged in from every direction without fear of death, each prepared to take an enemy with him.

It was not their martial arts that rattled the Elders, but their sheer momentum.

And amid that disruption, two men seized the opening without hesitation.

Shhk.

"Gah!"

A scream tore from the Third Elder's mouth. Before he knew what had happened, Wipeng's Sword Energy had surged up and carved through his side.

"Little brother!"

The Second Elder wavered at the scream of the sworn brother who had stood beside him for decades. For the briefest instant, his attention shifted elsewhere.

It cost him dearly.

Three swords thrust out at once, grazing him from head to toe. As the Second Elder hurriedly retreated, a bolt of lightning shot toward him.

Fwoooosh!

The instant he felt something cold burrow into his back, the Second Elder knew it was over.

Thuk!

It split flesh and severed bone. The Sword Energy rampaged like a living thing, tearing through his blood vessels and searing them.

How long had it been since he had felt pain like this?

The Second Elder's vision went white. Soon, he could no longer feel any pain at all.

"I, Jin Wikyung, Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, have cut down the Second Elder!"

As Jin Wikyung ripped his sword from the Second Elder's chest and roared, the Third Elder's head was falling not far away. Wipeng, soaked in blood, lifted it high.

"Here is the Third Elder's head!"

The survivors took up the cry.

"Wipe out the traitors!"

"The Jin Family of Taiyuan is not the enemy of the Mount Heng Sword Sect! Lower your swords!"

The shouts ringing out across the battlefield rallied the Jin Family's martial artists.

With its leadership all but wiped out, the Mount Heng Sword Sect had yet to find its bearings. Before long, however, its martial artists turned their weapons on the black-clad men.

"What are you doing? Those Jin Family bastards are right in front of us—"

"Enough of your nonsense. The only ones attacking us are those bastards in black!"

He was right. The Jin Family's martial artists were following their command's orders to the letter, and Mount Heng's people realized one of their enemies had dropped away.

The black-clad men who had appeared out of nowhere were now their common enemy.

"Show them the strength of the Mount Heng Sword Sect!"

"I don't know where you crawled out from, but wipe them all out!"

Once the two forces joined together, it was the black-clad men who began to give ground.

They were elites hardened by brutal training, but the deaths of the two Elders inevitably shook their morale. Blades rushed in from every direction, giving them no chance to recover, and the black-clad men began to fall one after another.

"Aaargh!"

"Don't fall back! Anyone who retreats will die!"

Even in that chaos, the First Elder swung his sword without a word.

Everything within his sight, everything within his reach, was his enemy.

Shhk.

Twenty? Thirty? He no longer knew. Like a man possessed, the First Elder cut down everything that stood in his way. Among them were people who had once addressed him with reverence and young men who looked barely twenty.

What does age matter when it comes to life and death? Anyone who stands before a blade is a person of Murim.

At last, a bear of a man blocked the path of the First Elder, who was drenched in the blood of dozens. His eyes looked ready to burn everything to ash.

"Why did you do it?"

"Wealth and glory. To seize the Jin Family of Taiyuan and swallow all of Shanxi."

The answer came without a hint of hesitation. Everyone trembled with rage.

Everyone but one.

Jin Wikyung shook his head.

"That isn't the answer I wanted."

"Then answer it yourself, Lesser Family Head. Why would my brothers, my lord, and I do such a thing?"

"Revenge."

Jin Wikyung continued in a quiet voice.

"The grand plan you spoke of wasn't meant to win you wealth and glory or make you ruler of a single province. Too many opportunities for that have already passed, and you're all old. And…"

"Enough."

"The Head Elder has no descendants. Neither do the Second Elder, the Third Elder, or you."

At that moment, a livid spark flared in the First Elder's placid eyes.

It was the anger he had suppressed for many long years, a remnant that surfaced for the briefest moment before sinking again.

"Why did you do it?"

Instead of answering, the First Elder raised his sword and pointed it at Jin Wikyung.

No—the tip pointed over Jin Wikyung's shoulder, toward someone somewhere beyond him.

"Hear it from him yourself."

In the end, the Head Elder held the final key.

Jin Wikyung strode toward the First Elder.

"I will. After I cut you down."

"Can you really afford to take your time like this?"

"What do you—"

Jin Wikyung's frown froze.

Taekyung!

His youngest brother, the apple of his eye, was holding off the Head Elder.

The instant he remembered what he had momentarily forgotten, all the blood in his body seemed to turn cold.

If I delay any longer, something irreversible will happen.

The moment Jin Wikyung grasped the full situation, his voice rang out like bitter frost.

“Wipeng. Take the First Elder.”

“I obey.”

“The rest of you, lend him your strength.”

“We follow the Lesser Family Head’s command.”

Wipeng and some ten surviving senior members spread into a wide ring around the First Elder.

“Everyone else, follow me and open a path! We’re going after the Head Elder!”

Jin Wikyung was about to depart with several dozen guards when he glanced back at the First Elder. Though his end was approaching, the old man showed no sign of agitation. If anything, he looked relieved.

“First Elder.”

“Do you have something left to say?”

Jin Wikyung tossed out a single sentence.

“By the authority of the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, I expel you from the family.”

“Heh heh. Heh heh heh!”

Leaving the First Elder’s laughter behind, Jin Wikyung raced toward the battlefield.

Dozens of black-clad men tried to stop him, but the tide had long since turned. Martial artists surged in from every direction and hacked them apart.

“Open a path!”

“It’s the Lesser Family Head! Kill anyone who stands in his way!”

It was only a moment. For Jin Wikyung, an eternity passed.

Taekyung. Please, please…

He could not even bring himself to think the word *death*.

How long had he run with his pounding chest clutched in his arms? When he finally reached his destination, his eyes flew wide.

What is this…?

The scene before him was utterly shocking.

Raid.

Until a few decades ago, it was a word used only in games.

But after the Demon King appeared and the Great Cataclysm began, raids became the defining symbol of Hunters.

Countless real battles had been fought and countless lives sacrificed along the way. Building on that experience, Hunters had finally established the modern method of raiding.

Tank, damage dealer, healer.

The tank blocks. The damage dealer attacks. The healer heals.

It sounded simple, but becoming a licensed Hunter required studying a mountain of raid manuals and proving yourself through actual combat.

Hunter training camp… That was a living hell.

But because I endured it, I came out a Hunter. Now, as a seven-year veteran, I can pull the right position and the right response for any situation.

And right now—

“Hey, throw dirt! Keep throwing it!”

I realized that everything I’d learned wasn’t worth shit.

Tank? Healer?

Fuck…

I was a fucking moron for thinking ten melee damage dealers counted as a raid.

Chapter 60

The Head Elder thought,

Have I lived too long?

The Murim he remembered had not been like this. Martial artists had not been like this.

Ganging up on an opponent was shameful. Ambushes were condemned. A man who got so much as dirt on his back became a laughingstock.

And yet…

“Throw dirt! Keep throwing it!”

In all his eighty years, he had never seen anything like this. What? Throw dirt?

It was a cheap, cowardly trick that not even the Demonic Cultists he had fought like mortal enemies decades ago had stooped to using.

Is that bastard truly a martial artist?

Even more appalling was the reaction of his so-called subordinates.

“Squad Leader’s orders! Throw dirt!”

“Keep your distance! Watch the Sword Energy!”

Watching the men obey without a word made his head spin.

What kind of goddamn bastards are these?

They were not martial artists.

No, they were not even human.

This was an insult to all martial artists—and to the Head Elder himself, who had devoted his entire life to the sword.

“How dare you…”

He was drawing his sword when—

“You idiots!”

A stern shout rang out half a beat sooner. A young man whose face was swollen as though he had been stung by a swarm of bees swept a fierce glare around him.

“What the hell do you think you’re doing?”

He looked ridiculous, but he had real spirit. Yes. That was how a martial artist ought to behave.

At least one of them has some sense.

The Head Elder was nodding to himself when the young man shouted,

“You think dirt’s enough? Mix in rocks too!”

“…!”

The Head Elder shuddered as though struck by lightning.

The humiliation was so unprecedented that he forgot even to swing his sword as a clod of dirt flew straight into his face.

Splat!

He could say with certainty that in all his eighty years, he had never taken an attack so humiliatingly or with his guard so completely down.

As the dirt pattered off him, he spotted a hefty rock thoughtfully mixed in with it.

“Uh-heh. Uh-heh-heh-heh.”

The Head Elder laughed like a madman.

Then his laughter abruptly stopped.

At the same moment—

Tssssss.

Sword Energy surged from his blade, laden with one jiazi[292] of internal energy.

“Are you prepared?”

Jin Taekyung watched him and muttered,

“Shouldn’t have mixed in the rocks…”

Before the words had even left his mouth, the Head Elder charged like a lion. The dozen or so sheep screamed and scattered.

“Spread out! Spread out!”

“Keep throwing dirt!”

Even as they fled, they did not forget to throw dirt.

Fwoooosh—

A fierce gale blasted from the tip of the Head Elder’s sword. Sand, dirt, stones—it made no difference. Before that overwhelming power, everything shattered and scattered.

How are we supposed to fight this guy?

Head-on?

Calling us melee damage dealers was being generous. If I sent the reconnaissance squad against the Head Elder, they’d be dying in heaps before I could blink.

I’d gotten attached to the bastards, though. I couldn’t let them die like dogs for nothing.

“Caaaptain!”

That bastard deserved to die, sure.

Why did you have to mix in rocks? Seriously, the rocks.

The Head Elder’s first target was Hyuk Mujin. Naturally. He had boldly struck the opening blow.

I heaved a deep sigh and launched myself toward him.

[292] *Jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; here, it describes the amount of internal energy accumulated over that span.

Shiiiiing!

I thrust my spear at the Head Elder's chest with all my strength.

The Sword Energy about to carve through Hyuk Mujin's back immediately changed direction.

Shing.

That goddamn Sword Energy.

There was no time to look at the spearhead it had sliced clean off. I snatched the terrified Hyuk Mujin by the scruff of his neck.

"Run!"

But the Head Elder was not about to give up so easily.

Swoooosh!

The air shrieked, and my side burned. A mere graze tore away a handful of flesh and sent blood spraying.

Kh.

It hurt like hell. But right now, even screaming was a luxury.

I need to buy time.

I shoved Hyuk Mujin aside and turned back. The Head Elder raised an eyebrow.

"You?"

It was only one word, but the meaning came through perfectly.

You think the likes of you can stop me?

I answered as calmly as I could.

"Yeah. Me."

"Do you not value your life?"

"If I tell you it's damn precious, will you let me live?"

"Heh heh. What an insolent tongue for one so young."

"Gramps, does your pecker still stand?"

Tssssss.

It rose ramrod straight.

Large, magnificent Sword Energy.

"…Still going strong, I see."

The hand gripping my spear grew slick with sweat.

Looks like I'll have to use every last trick I've got if I want to survive this.

I had far more secrets than the Head Elder knew.

I could attack using my Inventory, and I had One Annihilation—a Skill that poured several times my normal strength into a single blow.

I've never shown it to anyone, just in case something like this happened.

Was this what people in Murim called a final, last-resort technique?

One thing was certain. Neither the Head Elder nor anyone else in Murim would see it coming.

And on top of that…

“Encircling formation. Form up.”

Shff.

Hyuk Mujin and the reconnaissance squad began closing in from every direction.

A flimsy net for a fish as big as the Head Elder.

But with a sharp enough harpoon, we had a chance.

“You think this will be enough?”

“To catch one old man? More than enough.”

The Head Elder smiled, amused.

“What a fearless brat. The kind who only comes to his senses after a beating.”

But he never got the chance. A voice suddenly cut in.

“I must have misheard you. Say that again.”

A mountain of a man stood there, his eyes wide and fierce. The voice that emerged from between his thick lips was cold as ice.

“You said you were going to lay a hand on our boy?”

Fwoooosh.

Sword Energy blazed up along his blade like wildfire and pointed at the Head Elder.

Jin Wikyung had appeared like a savior. He winked at me.

“Well? Your big brother looks cool, doesn’t he?”

Still the same.

It was the first time I had seen that face in a month.

The moment Jin Wikyung appeared, the tension drained from my body.

I was glad.

Just glad.

Thank goodness he’s alive.

Wikyung was covered in blood, as though he had fought a brutal battle to get here. Wounds large and small showed through the tears in his clothes.

But that was enough. All that mattered was that he was alive.

There’s a lot I want to say, but it can wait.

We could have our reunion after the war was over. Wikyung seemed to feel the same way. He turned his gaze forward.

At the end of our gazes, the Head Elder slowly began to speak.

“If you have made it this far, then…”

Jin Wikyung's icy voice cut him off.

"The Second and Third Elders are dead. The First Elder is only a matter of time."

That was good news. If Wikyung put it that way, the Elders must have played a major role in this war.

The Head Elder had lost his hands and feet.

"Did the two of them… go peacefully?"

"Probably."

The Head Elder nodded readily.

"They always said they wished to die fighting as martial artists. They got their wish. I'm glad."

"They'll be remembered as traitors, not martial artists. Every last one of you."

"History is written by the victors."

The Head Elder leveled his sword at us. Even before dozens of men, including me and Jin Wikyung, he stood utterly composed.

"Now, let us decide who the victor will be."

Jin Wikyung opened his mouth as if he had something to say, then closed it firmly.

The next moment, a thunderous roar burst from him.

"Strike down the rebels!"

Shing. Shrrring.

Dozens of weapons were drawn at once, all aimed at a single man. It was quite a sight.

"We obey!"

With a tremendous shout, dozens of martial artists charged as one. I was no exception. My grip tightened around my spear, and my chest felt ready to burst.

We can win. No. We win, no matter what.

It was an all-out melee without the slightest formation. But we had Jin Wikyung, a Peak master, and dozens of martial artists at his back.

And there's me.

The Head Elder had placed too much faith in his own strength. He had committed every last man to the front without keeping even a minimal guard around himself. As a result, the black-clad men were now pinned down by the combined assault of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

The Head Elder…

dies right here.

It's over!

It did not take long for that certainty to shatter.

Shushushushush!

Dozens of tiny points shot out of nowhere, slicing through the air faster and harder than any of us had expected.

"It's the finger-flicking technique!"

Jin Wikyung's shout rang out, but I had no time to wonder what that was.

Pow-pow-pow-pow!

Clang!

"Aaargh!"

"Guh!"

Some men fell. Others knocked the projectiles aside.

Those who fell did not rise again.

Don't tell me…

It had lasted only an instant, but I had seen it clearly. Tiny fragments were embedded like buckshot around their hearts and across their faces.

Stones?

They were little more than shards now, but they had definitely been stones. Unable to withstand the Head Elder's internal energy, they had shattered the moment he fired them at us.

That's possible?

Goose bumps rose across my skin, but it was not over.

The Head Elder was extending one hand toward us.

"Scatter!"

This time, Wikyung and I shouted at once. The martial artists, already on high alert, scattered in every direction.

Good. We weren't too late this ti—

My relief lasted only a moment.

Swoooosh!

This time, what came shooting at us was not the finger-flicking technique.

It was the Head Elder.

He plunged into the martial artists and rampaged among them like a wild beast.

Slash. Slash. Slash.

"Grrk."

"Hhk."

Each time his sword flashed through the darkness, another life went out. Wherever the Head Elder passed, he left only strangled screams and corpses behind.

"Head Elder!"

Jin Wikyung charged at him in fury. By then, the Head Elder had already killed five people. Yet his pale face remained untouched by so much as a drop of blood, making him look like a ghost.

“You’ve come?”

“How dare you!”

“You’re all so clumsy. Peace must have lasted too long.”

There was one undeniable fact.

The Head Elder was a hero of the Great Faction War.

He was stronger and more experienced than anyone else here—a Peak martial artist honed through countless battles.

Shiiiiing!

The Sword Energy Jin Wikyung unleashed stabbed through empty air. The Head Elder evaded it with nothing more than a slight tilt of his head, then flicked a finger.

His target was me.

Shhk!

I could not see a thing, but instinct told me what it was.

Internal energy.

It was exactly that—a solid mass of qi.

I threw myself into a roll without hesitation.

Pshk.

“Guh.”

I should have blocked it with my spear, but the attack was too unfamiliar for me to think that far ahead.

An unnamed ally paid the price with his life.

I felt rotten.

“Narye tagon? You truly are a donkey.”[293]

I spat out the dirt in my mouth.

“When your life’s on the line, you do whatever it takes.”

“Haha. You’ve already become a proper man of Murim.”

Clang! Clang-clang-clang!

What kind of monster was this?

Even as he spoke, the Head Elder deflected every one of Jin Wikyung’s Sword Energy attacks. The sight left me speechless.

Thud!

Even then, a fist loaded with internal energy smashed the skull of a martial artist who’d gone for his back.

[293] *Narye tagon* is a humiliating evasive roll likened to a lazy donkey rolling on the ground.

“You’re still twenty years too early.”

The battle had barely begun. Not even enough time had passed to drink a cup of tea, yet nearly twenty martial artists had already become cold corpses.

“You bastard!”

Shiiiiing!

A middle-aged warrior whose face looked vaguely familiar lost his head to Sword Energy.

“Die!”

Boom!

A young man with a baby face that might have been twenty had his chest caved in and dropped to his knees.

They were not NPCs.

They were real people.

Faces I had seen at least once around the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Faces belonging to people whose hands I had shaken.

I gritted my teeth.

I’m sorry.

I was not apologizing because I lacked the power to stop it. I was apologizing because I had used their deaths.

Shhk!

Another man fell to the Head Elder’s finger-flicking technique like a puppet with its strings cut. But just as the corpse seemed about to topple backward, it sprang upright like a roly-poly toy.

Then it pitched toward the Head Elder.

“Cheap trick!”

Boom! Bang!

With one hand, the Head Elder blocked Jin Wikyung’s sword. With the other, he sent a palm strike hurtling into the corpse.

And then…

Now.

Hidden behind the corpse as it flew through the air, I thrust my spear.

“One Annihilation.”

The next instant—

Goooooong.

A deafening roar left my ears numb.

Chapter 61

Gooooong.

The Head Elder felt the air tremble. At the same instant, he grasped the destructive power behind the spearhead hurtling toward his chest.

This is… dangerous.

He had felt his life threatened this keenly only a handful of times. Every hair on his body stood on end, and the world slowed.

Shiiiiing!

Jin Taekyung's spear came from the front, while Jin Wikyung's sword flew in from behind. The two brothers' coordinated attack came together with perfect timing.

A true life-or-death moment.

Fwoooosh.

The one jiazi[294] of internal energy coiled in the Head Elder's dantian spread through every limb and bone. It poured vitality into his aging muscles and woke his blood vessels. The change did not stop there.

Tssssss.

The Sword Energy that had extended nearly a foot[295] compressed to half its length.

But this was not a loss of power. It was a concentration of it.

The threadlike Sword Energy wrapped around the entire blade, taking the shape of another sword.

Sword Force.

The symbol of the superhuman masters who had broken through the wall of the Peak realm and opened a great new domain.

It was still incomplete, no more than half-formed, but it was unmistakably Sword Force—the culmination of the martial arts the Head Elder had spent his life mastering.

Shhk.

Even the Jin Family of Taiyuan's ancestral treasure sword was severed, Sword Energy and all. Jin Wikyung's internal energy scattered in an instant, the shock wrenching his insides. His face went pale.

One stroke would have been enough to take his neck.

But the Head Elder had no time.

Shwack!

He reached for the spear now almost at his chest. His wrinkled hand, too, was wrapped in a dazzling radiance of qi.

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[294] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[295] The source measures this length as nearly one *ja*, a Korean unit equal to about 30.3 cm (11.9 in).

It, too, was an incomplete Palm Force, but it was enough to stop Jin Taekyung's spear.

No. It looked like enough.

Kraaaaaash!

Until the vortex pouring from the spearhead swallowed him whole.

A deathly silence descended. It felt as though the dozens gathered here—perhaps everyone on the battlefield—were watching us.

No.

Not us.

One man.

"This…"

At the center of countless gazes, the Head Elder slowly opened his mouth.

"What form was that?"

I answered.

"One Annihilation."

Even saying the words brought on a ravenous hunger. Every muscle in my body stung, and not a scrap of internal energy remained inside me.

But that was all.

Unlike when I'd fought Jopil, I neither passed out nor collapsed pathetically to the ground.

My body can handle it now.

I had grown strong enough to withstand One Annihilation's side effects. And as I had grown, so had One Annihilation's power.

The Head Elder's condition was proof of that.

"One Annihilation. One Annihilation…"

Muttering under his breath, he pressed an acupoint on his shoulder.

The bleeding stopped, but that was all. The arm ground away without a trace by One Annihilation's vortex did not return.

"I never thought I'd end up one-armed at my age. Heh heh."

The Head Elder gave a hollow laugh and turned toward Jin Wikyung.

"You have a frightening younger brother."

Jin Wikyung asked, his face wan, "Does that child frighten you?"

"What about you?"

"I'm proud of him."

There was not a hint of hesitation in his answer. A smile spread across his pale face.

"I raised him like gold and jade, but he grew into steel. That's the kind of child Taekyung is."

The Head Elder stared at his smile.

"You're quite a capable man. Worthy of shouldering the future of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Am I?"

"But not as much as your younger brothers."

Jin Mukyung had reached the Peak realm at twenty, so that was understandable. But ranking even me that highly was almost more praise than I could handle…

What is he getting at?

As though he had read my mind, the Head Elder continued.

"Power is the one thing a man will not share, even with his own blood. When the time comes, will you still be so proud of your younger brothers?"

The air around us went ice-cold in an instant.

Everyone facing the Head Elder at close range belonged to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Cautious looks clung to my cheeks, then quietly slid away.

Family Head? I have no intention of becoming anything like that, you bastards.

That was when Jin Wikyung spoke.

"So that was it."

Bitterness and relief mingled in his voice. The Head Elder's brow twitched.

"What are you talking about?"

"The reason you betrayed us. The reason today came to pass."

"…!"

The Head Elder's trembling eyes answered for him. I sighed inwardly.

So that was what this was about.

A succession struggle.

It felt as though a huge piece of the puzzle had clicked into place. The smaller pieces still out of position began falling into place one by one as they spoke.

"What happened?"

Jin Wikyung asked respectfully.

The shift in his tone was so natural that no one else seemed to notice.

"Do you know anything about your grandfather?"

"I have heard nothing. Father never spoke a word of him."

"He was a coldhearted man. Toward his children and his only younger brother alike. And…"

The Head Elder gave a dry little laugh.

"He was petty. For many reasons, we gradually drifted apart despite once being close brothers. Then it happened."

“The Great Faction War.”

“Have you heard of the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples? They came in endless waves. The Murim Alliance was formed, but it was little more than a coalition of the Nine Sects and One Gang, each too busy defending its own territory.”

That was also when the Head Elder had begun making a real name for himself.

He rallied Shanxi’s martial artists beneath the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s banner and ultimately drove out the Demonic Cult’s forces.

“The final battle took place right here, at Eight Spring Gorge.”

His gaze seemed to grope toward some distant point in the past.

“It had been a long war. Many had died, and everyone was exhausted. But we still had hope—the hope that we could finally return to our families. All three hundred members of the death squad shared that hope.”

“In the end, you won a great victory.”

Three hundred against three thousand.

The result was the Demonic Cult’s annihilation.

It was a glorious victory and the reason the Head Elder was still remembered to this day. Everyone had believed that without question.

Until just now.

“There was an ambush.”

What?

“We fought while retreating deep into the gorge, but we were hopelessly outnumbered. Even as I swung my sword like a madman, one question refused to leave me.”

The Head Elder’s voice was chillingly calm.

“How could they have set an ambush in advance? My elder brother should have been blocking the road into Eight Spring Gorge.”

“…!”

Silent shock rippled through the crowd. The last traces of color vanished from Jin Wikyung’s already pale face.

“The battle lasted half a day. We fought waiting for reinforcements that never came, and it was useless. Of the three hundred volunteers, only eight survived. When we finally returned to the family, I have never been able to forget the look on my brother’s face when he saw me.”

“Is that… true?”

“Enough time has passed for mountains and rivers to change several times over. Did you think I had come this far on mere suspicion?”

Decades were more than enough time for suspicion to harden into certainty. The Head Elder laughed hollowly.

“My brother turned the war into an opportunity. I became a hero on the battlefield, but he became Family Head. Everyone who had followed me either died in battle or vanished afterward.”

“Then was that why you entered the Council of Elders immediately afterward?”

“Because only then would he feel at ease. Because only then could my people and I remain alive.”

My people?

I thought back to what he had said. The eight survivors who had followed the Head Elder and lived to the end.

It wasn’t difficult to guess who they were.

The Elders and the Sect Leaders of the Five Gates of Shanxi.

The survivors had sworn revenge—revenge against the Family Head and the family that had betrayed them.

The Head Elder slowly swept his gaze over the crowd.

“It had been a very long wait.”

Silence swallowed everyone. Disbelief, shock, shame—their emotions differed, but no one could bring themselves to speak.

Well, no one except me.

“You sure dragged that bullshit out.”

“…!”

I couldn’t hold back the little snorts of laughter leaking out of me.

I had listened all the way through to see where this was going, and this was what I got.

“In the end, you only have one goal.”

I jerked my thumb at the Head Elder.

“Revenge, my ass. You’re trying to become the man on top, aren’t you?”

“What did you say?”

“I’m right, aren’t I? Get rid of everything in your way—the Jin Family of Taiyuan, the Mount Heng Sword Sect—and swallow Shanxi whole.”

“You insolent—!”

Had the old man swallowed a locomotive boiler? Oh, right. No trains here.

“Revenge? Sure. Fine, revenge…”

I picked at my ear and continued.

“But why now?”

This had happened a full forty years ago. Even counting the Head Elder’s age, he had waited half his life.

“How many of the people who stabbed you in the back are even still alive? There’s being late, and then there’s this. And please, I’m begging you—don’t give me that

bullshit about a junzi[296] waiting ten years to take revenge."

If waiting ten years made you a junzi[297], did waiting forty make the Head Elder Jesus?

This was nothing more than a crazy old man trying to justify himself.

"You run your mouth just because you've got one."

"I did. What are you going to do about it?"

"Do you think you know everything?"

"Do I need to? After things have gone this far?"

The question was so obvious I snorted a laugh and pointed at the battlefield.

A mountain of corpses and a sea of blood. Utter pandemonium. The scene before us was exactly that.

"That…"

The cold light in the Head Elder's eyes wavered. But only for an instant.

"I see. What more is there to say?"

He muttered the words in self-mockery, then raised his sword.

"Head Elder."

Jin Wikyung's lips moved, but that was all.

This fight would end only when one side died. They had come too far to turn back.

"Come."

I wasn't about to refuse.

"Attack!"

It was time to hunt the wounded beast.

I remembered the day I first saw the Head Elder.

A bearing and dignity that made his age meaningless. His white beard called an immortal to mind.

Fwoosh!

Of course, there were no immortals who mercilessly cut people in half.

Even rotten, a prized fish is still a prized fish.

Drenched in blood, he swung his sword without pause. Everyone stared at him with a mixture of awe and fear.

"Monster…"

The Head Elder had lost an arm, but he was still strong.

He was clearly no longer as strong as before, though.

This is doable.

[296] A *junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

[297] A *junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

The Head Elder might have been a Peak master, but the martial artists here were the Jin Family of Taiyuan's elite. They had fought across the battlefield under Jin Wikyung and were skilled enough to have survived their earlier clash with the Head Elder.

Clang-clang-clang!

The Head Elder knocked away the blades driving at him from every direction, his face darkening. Before, he would have used Sword Energy to cut through everything in his path.

It was proof that the internal energy that had once seemed like an inexhaustible spring was finally running dry.

On top of that, his aged body had reached its limit.

Shraaaak!

Sword wounds began to multiply across the Head Elder's body. Unlike before, most of the blood was now his.

Now!

I wasn't about to miss that opening. I drove my spear forward with all my strength, tearing a handful of flesh from his side.

"Hk!"

Even through the pain, the Head Elder cut down another martial artist and lunged at me. He had clearly set his mind on killing me; faint Sword Energy gathered along his swinging blade.

But…

Shhk.

The Sword Energy scattered in a rising spray of blood. Jin Wikyung appeared behind the staggering Head Elder.

"I'd forgotten you were there."

The Head Elder turned, his face twisting.

"Did my elder brother teach you to put a blade in someone's back?"

"My family members are dying. Is a sneak attack really that important?"

"Aren't you ashamed as a martial artist?"

"I am the Lesser Family Head before I am a martial artist."

"The Lesser Family Head, is it? Heh heh."

Jin Wikyung regarded the Head Elder with a complicated expression.

"The tide has already turned."

"So? Are you going to ask me to surrender?"

"Please put an end to this meaningless fight."

The battle had turned in our favor long ago. But the black-clad men continued their stubborn resistance, and the screams and corpses showed no sign of diminishing.

"You're right. Perhaps this is a meaningless fight. But…"

The staggering Head Elder straightened his back. A sharp gleam flashed in his eyes, and a blade-like aura began to rise from him.

"We've come too far to stop."

A last desperate struggle?

No. It was more than that. Someone suddenly came to mind.

Jopil.

The Head Elder's current appearance overlapped with Jopil's final moments before his death.

Innate qi. He's drawing out his innate qi.

Internal energy was acquired power accumulated by circulating qi and consuming elixirs. Innate qi was the opposite—the foundation of the human body, life force itself.

The Head Elder was staking his life to use it.

"Cough."

He spat out blood and raised his sword. His life was fading rapidly, yet his sword shone more brilliantly than ever.

The moment I saw that overwhelming sight, a single word slipped out of me.

"Sword Force…"

It was instinct.

My heart pounded from the mere sight of it. I could feel a terrifying power that far surpassed Sword Energy.

And then—

"Yes. You were here."

His blood-red eyes, their capillaries bursting one after another, locked on me.

Jin Wikyung lunged to stop the Head Elder.

"No!"

But the Head Elder had already vanished from where he stood.

In a single step he compressed fifty feet[298] and brought his sword down on me.

Whoooong.

So this is how I die.

It was an attack I could neither dodge nor block.

I was dead. I was going to die.

But…

I can't die like this.

I wrung every ounce of strength from my muscles. The last scant handful of internal energy raced toward the spearhead.

[298] The source measures this distance as five *jang*, about 15.15 m (49.7 ft).

It was a final struggle, and a show of respect for the life I had lived so fiercely until now.

“One Annihilation.”

Shiiiiiiing!

My final strike, carrying every last bit of strength I had, shot forward.

Chapter 62

The world seemed to stop.

My heartbeat thundered in my ears, and I could see every last grain of dirt drifting through the air.

And then…

Whoooosh.

A flash of light.

The glow pouring from the Sword Force was beautiful—and unerring. I could feel the devastating power in it, enough to split not only my spearhead but my body itself in two.

It's over.

I had done my best. It would be a lie to say I had no regrets at all, but that wouldn't change the outcome.

All I could do was meet it with everything I had left.

Shwaaaak!

The spearhead tore through the wind. The Sword Force erased it.

That was the instant death came striding in.

Shreeeek! Thunk!

The Head Elder's eyes flew wide.

A mysterious figure had sprung up with lightning speed and driven a dagger into his dantian.

"You…"

"You should've struck a lethal acupoint."

It was an ambush no one could have expected.

Until a moment ago, he had been nothing more than one of the countless corpses scattered around us.

But he wasn't.

He had merely been waiting with extraordinary patience for the right moment—the moment he could avenge his child.

The Head Elder screamed.

"Lee Cheonbaek!"

"Kahahaha!"

The instant Lee Cheonbaek burst into wild laughter, my spearhead punched into his back.

It tore through flesh and bone, driving forward without resistance.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 75 Lee Cheonbaek!
Level up!
Level up!
Level up!
...
All status ailments have been recovered due to the stacked effect of the level-ups!

The change came at once.

My aching muscles, my heavy feet, my empty dantian—all of them swelled with new strength.

At the same time, I knew what I had to do.

One Annihilation.

Once more, a white vortex erupted.

Kraaaack!

A narrow escape.[299]

Never in my life had those four syllables hit so close to home.

I had really died and come back. I'd even seen a vision of going through immigration into hell, sharing a passionate hug with Yama,[300] and snapping a commemorative photo together.

If it hadn't been for Lee Cheonbaek, that vision would have become reality.

Good thing I saved him.

I wanted to close Lee Cheonbaek's eyes so he could rest in peace, but there was still work to do.

"Should've lived a decent life, then. Just a little."

The Head Elder gave a quiet laugh. He looked horrific.

One Annihilation had swallowed his remaining arm, and it hadn't stopped there—it had punched a hole the size of a fist through his chest.

"What a nasty-hearted brat. Have you no manners toward a dying old man?"

"The old folks I know spend their twilight years enjoying their grandchildren's antics. They don't run around trying to kill them like you, you old bastard."

"Why, you brat! Try acting like a grandson before you say something like that."

[299] *Gusa ilsaeng* is a four-syllable Korean idiom meaning a narrow escape from death.
[300] Yama is the ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

He laughed heartily. He looked deflated, yet relieved, as though he had finally let go of everything.

“Taekyung is a good kid. If you had opened your heart first, the two of you might have been close as grandfather and grandson.”

The Head Elder turned his head.

Jin Wikyung stood there, sword in hand.

“Are you planning to stab me with that sword?”

“I’m considering it.”

“You’d better finish considering it quickly. I don’t have much time left.”

His words were true.

Even now, as he talked as though nothing were wrong, blood poured like a waterfall from the severed stumps of both arms and from his lower abdomen.

On top of that, there was the backlash from drawing out his innate qi.

The fact that he was still alive felt like a miracle.

“You look like you’re suffering.”

“No. I’m growing comfortable.”

The answer was firm.

“I was barely thirty when the Great Faction War began. After that, I never once rested easy—not even for a moment. No…”

The Head Elder went on in a strained voice.

“In truth, perhaps I’ve been tired for a very long time.”

I muttered in disbelief.

“You did all that, and now you’re coming out with this?”

“Taekyung!”

Jin Wikyung sent me a mildly reproachful look, but the Head Elder did not seem offended. A breathy laugh escaped his closed lips.

“Puh-huh. Yes, you’re right. Just think of it as a senile old man’s bullshit.”

“Looks like it really is time for you to die.”

“Hey! You little brat!”

“What? It’s not like I said anything wrong.”

The Head Elder watched Jin Wikyung and me bicker through fading eyes.

“There was a time when we were like you two. Yes. There certainly was.”

But he no longer had time to linger over those memories.

“Cough! Guaaack!”

The Head Elder staggered after vomiting what looked like a whole bowlful of blood.

He was at death’s door. Every capillary in his eyes had burst, and the blood pouring from his body had long since pooled at his feet.

Anyone could see there was no hope left for him.

He's really dying? That Head Elder?

Everyone dies.

Hundreds of lives had vanished on this battlefield alone—perhaps more than a thousand.

But the Head Elder's death was something I had never even been able to imagine.

That was how overwhelming his martial prowess had been. It made his current state look all the more wretched.

And that only made me more curious.

"Why are you holding on this hard?"

The Head Elder answered.

"Because I want to tell those who went before me… that I did my best."

"Any regrets?"

"None."

He smiled broadly and thrust out his chest.

"Finish it. With your own hands."

I raised my spear.

Jin Wikyung wore a troubled expression, but he did not try to stop me.

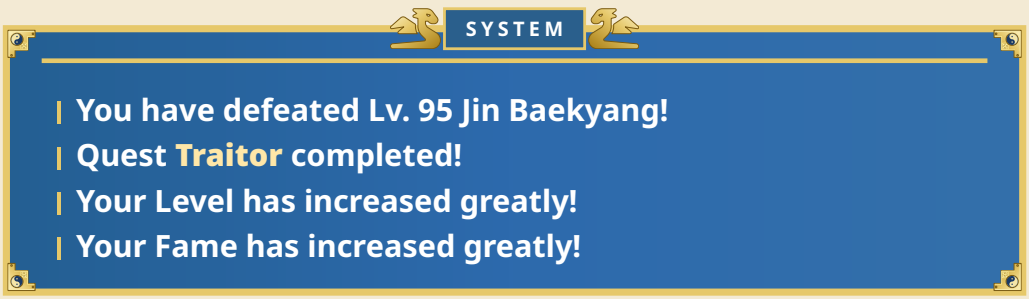
Shhk!

A single gust of wind passed, and the Head Elder's knees—which had seemed incapable of ever buckling—touched the ground.

A peaceful smile appeared on his wrinkled face.

At the final moment, his lips moved, but no sound came out.

That was all.



For one brief moment, silence fell.

Then a colossal roar erupted—unlike anything I had ever heard.

"The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung, has cut down the Blade of Flowers, Jin Baekyang!"

SYSTEM

You have acquired the Title **Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!**

Dozens.

Maybe hundreds.

Every survivor was shouting my name.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

I rather liked my new name.

“Third Young Master Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan cut down the Head Elder!”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi defeated the Blade of Flowers!”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi…”

Wipeng gave a quiet laugh.

He was the wastrel Third Young Master who had never even been called an earth dragon.[301]

But now, there was no denying it.

He was a Hidden Dragon.

If he obtained the dragon pearl,[302] he could roam the azure heaven.

“What do you make of it?”

The First Elder answered.

“Do you believe that?”

“Everyone is shouting that the Head Elder is dead.”

“That is because my lord wanted it that way. A mere Third Young Master killing him? It’s laughable.”

“You can see that from here? Sharp eyes.”

“This is what comes of letting your attention wander. Hahaha.”

He was leaning at an angle against a heap of corpses.

A sword wound split him on a slant from about the shoulder to the waist, and blood poured from it in torrents.

“Surrender. If we treat you now, you can live.”

“No. This old man’s end was decided long ago. A very painful death.”

Wipeng shook his head.

“I won’t allow it.”

[301] The Korean term for “earth dragon” also refers to an earthworm, making it a lowly contrast to “Hidden Dragon.”

[302] The dragon pearl is a legendary jewel associated with dragons in East Asian tradition.

“My death does not require permission. Neither you nor even I can do anything about it.”

“What does that mean?”

Wipeng furrowed his brow, unable to follow, when—

“Beware Dark Heaven… Grrk.”

It happened in an instant.

Blood poured from all seven of the First Elder’s orifices. His eyes rolled back, and his entire body convulsed.

“First Elder!”

By the time Wipeng hurried over, the First Elder had already stopped breathing.

Just as he had said, he had met a painful death. His face was twisted grotesquely.

This is…

Poison? Or a restriction?

There was no way to know yet.

Wipeng carved the single word that had become the First Elder’s last deep into his mind.

Dark Heaven. He definitely said Dark Heaven.

It was the only clue the First Elder had left behind.

Wipeng stared at the dead man’s face with mixed emotions, then turned away.

“I, Wipeng, cut down the First Elder!”

Despair spread across the faces of the black-clad men.

Faced with two paths—death or surrender—they chose the latter.

Clang. Clatter-clatter.

Weapons fell limply to the ground.

The war was over.

Where there were the dead, there were also survivors.

Jin Chung, Sect Leader of the Gunggui Sect,[303] was one of them. He had climbed to the top of the cliff before the battle began.

“How futile.”

It had been a grand scheme to which he had devoted half his life.

The result had been disastrous.

The Head Elder he had served as his lord, the Elders he had treated as brothers, and the Sect Leaders of the Five Gates of Shanxi were all dead.

The survivors’ last desperate struggle was over as well.

[303] The characters in *Gunggui* (□□) mean “bow” and “ghost.”

Now, only he remained.

So this is how it ends.

Jin Chung turned around.

Fifty martial artists of the Gunggui Sect were waiting for his orders.

“Leave.”

A subtle ripple of agitation passed through them.

One of the nearest martial artists spoke cautiously.

“Sect Leader, what do you mean…?”

“This fight is already over. I will not force you to sacrifice yourselves. Leave by this road. Scatter as widely as you can and get out of Shanxi. If you do, you may at least save your lives.”

The martial artist nodded resolutely.

“I will follow you until I die.”

“I… will remain here.”

“What?”

His confusion lasted only a moment before his voice began to tremble with emotion.

“Is it because of us?”

“Not at all.”

Jin Chung answered firmly, but his thoughts were different.

If I went with them, the Jin Family of Taiyuan would hunt them relentlessly.

The Five Gates of Shanxi were many, yet one.

One, yet many.

They had been created for the same purpose, but each sect had raised its martial artists in a different way.

Jin Chung had not raised them as weapons.

He had taken them in as disciples.

“Sect Leader!”

“Please lead us!”

Every one of them had been an orphan with nowhere to go.

For at least ten years—twenty or more in some cases—he had fed them, sheltered them, and taught them martial arts.

If the grand scheme had succeeded, they would have become the backbone of Shanxi’s Murim.

Now that it had failed, they were nothing more than traitors.

“Do you not understand what’s happening?”

“Even if we die, we will stay with you, Sect Leader.”

“You fool!”

“Please allow us.”

The martial artist who had stepped forward first slammed his forehead against the stone ground.

Then, one by one, his disciples began to kneel.

Jin Chung looked up at the sky and lamented.

“If only the grand scheme had not been delayed. If only they had stepped forward!”

Talk of *them* was a secret known only to the eight leaders.

Speaking those words aloud was no different from deciding to share his final moments with his disciples.

This too must be heaven’s will.

Jin Chung turned his gaze from the dark night sky and helped the prostrate martial artist to his feet.

He felt endlessly sorry—and deeply moved—by the loyalty the man had shown.

“That’s enough. Get up.”

At the warmth in his voice, the martial artist lifted his head.

He flicked his tongue over the trickle of blood running down his forehead, then gave a crooked grin.

“Yes.”

Thuck!

Jin Chung stared blankly at the martial artist.

The shock was so great he could not even feel the pain.

What in the world…?

Shwaaak!

The martial artist pulled his hand from Jin Chung’s chest.

A glow brighter than moonlight clung to it—a blood-red Force so ominous that the mere sight of it inspired dread.

“You…”

“You already know, so why ask? Oh, and about what you just said—I’ll give you a simple answer.”

The martial artist’s smile deepened.

“Why would we step forward? This is as far as your role goes.”

Jin Chung’s eyes flew wide.

Them.

The unknown beings who had never revealed themselves until the very end.

Dark Heaven!

“You bastards!”

“Don’t look at me like you’ve been used. Have you forgotten who got you out of that hell alive?”

Jin Chung remembered the nightmare from forty years ago.

The corpses of allies covering the ground around him.

The endless army of the Demonic Cult surging toward them.

They had gathered around the Head Elder and prepared themselves to die.

That was before Dark Heaven appeared.

“We saved your lives and gave you a chance at revenge. What more did you want?”

He was right.

Dark Heaven had annihilated the Demonic Cult’s army, then proposed a deal.

They had accepted.

It meant having a gu[304] planted in their heads, but they would have done anything for revenge.

But…

“Wasn’t your real aim to use us to rule Shanxi?”

“Well, maybe that was the plan at first.”

“Then what was it all for?”

The martial artist grinned.

“A bigger picture.”

At the same time, his bloodstained hand pressed against Jin Chung’s chest.

Boom.

A small explosion went off inside Jin Chung’s body.

The energy burst his eardrums, tore his blood vessels apart strand by strand, and reached his heart.

Just like this…

The thought went no further.

Jin Chung’s lifeless body flew like a bird and plunged off the cliff.

Shiiiiik! Crash!

The martial artist glanced down and grimaced.

“Ouch. That must’ve hurt.”

When he turned around, screams and blood were waiting for him.

Ten black-clad men who had appeared out of nowhere were massacring the Gunggui Sect’s disciples.

“Let’s finish this quickly and go.”

“As you command.”

---

[304] A *gu* is a traditional poison associated with venomous creatures; in Murim fiction, it may be implanted in a person’s body.

Shreeeeek! Thud!

The martial artist turned his gaze toward the bottom of the cliff.

Screams erupted all around him, but below the cliff, the air was filled with cheers and shouts.

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

“Jin Taekyung! Jin Taekyung!”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi…”

The plan had succeeded.

But Jin Taekyung’s appearance had been a variable even he had not anticipated.

He did not like that.

Take him out, or let him be?

If he set his mind to it, he could tear him out by the roots.

His deepening gaze turned toward Jin Taekyung, ringed by cheers.

“Our youngest! My little brother!”

“Let go! Let go, you idiot!”

A snort of laughter escaped him.

I’ll let you live. For today.

The martial artist turned away.

Some fifty corpses lay like a carpet in his wake.

Chapter 63

Creeeak.

The man entered the inn around early afternoon.

The old wooden door creaked, but no one inside turned to look. Not even the owner and the waiter, who should have been rushing to greet a customer.

“So? So what happened?”

“Quit keeping us in suspense and tell us already!”

At the crowd’s eager urging, the old man tapped his empty bowl.

Only after the owner filled it to overflowing with bamboo-leaf wine did the old man—the storyteller—continue.

“A fierce battle broke out. Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek brought no fewer than thirty thousand men. Against them, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had only three hundred elites.”

“Thirty thousand!”

“My word, thirty thousand!”

“Does that make any sense? Mount Heng Sword Sect isn’t one of the Nine Sects and One Gang[305]…”

The storyteller stopped mid-sip and spat the wine back out.

“Fuck this. This booze tastes like shit. I’m leaving. You can hear the rest from the guy who brought up the Nine Sects and One Gang.”

“Now, hold on. Why are you doing this?”

“Who just said that?”

The mood turned ugly, and a young man was shoved back, half-stumbling.

Only then did the storyteller lower his half-raised ass back onto his seat. He was offended now, and that had made him bolder.

Tap, tap.

Everyone frowned as the storyteller tapped his empty bowl. Now they had to give him money, not more wine. They were in the middle of an unspoken standoff when—

Ting.

“Huh?”

The storyteller’s narrowed eyes flew open. A gleaming silver nyang[306] had come flying from somewhere.

“Well. Whoever that is, they’re a big spender.”

“Who was it?”

---

[305] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a conventional grouping of major martial sects and the Beggars’ Gang in martial-arts fiction.

[306] A silver nyang is a unit of silver currency used in the story’s historical setting.

“Why are you looking at me? You trying to get me beaten to death by my wife?”

That was when someone spoke from behind the crowd.

“I’d like to hear more.”

The voice was quiet but resonant. It belonged to the man who had entered the inn earlier. His face was hidden beneath a bamboo hat pulled low, and the cloak wrapped around him was caked with dust.

A martial artist.

Nobody needed to say it. Everyone in the inn came to the same conclusion.

The storyteller looked from the silver to the man and swallowed.

“Thank you, Great Hero. Is there something in particular you’d like to hear…?”

In his experience, ruffians and martial artists were only a hair apart. He was an old man who had lived his share of years, but he had no desire to get stabbed to death in a place like this.

Fortunately, the man in the bamboo hat belonged to the latter group.

“Keep it simple. Just the facts.”

Judging by his voice, he was clearly a young bastard—but a young bastard who had learned martial arts. The storyteller couldn’t treat him carelessly. He rubbed his palms together.

“I’ll tell you everything I know, sir. The whole lot.”

“That battle you mentioned. How many days ago was it?”

“Five days ago.”

“Who won?”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan wiped the floor with them. I heard the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi played a major role.”

“Then Mount Heng Sword Sect… What did you just say?”

“Excuse me?”

“Shanxi, what?”

“Ah, you mean the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“That’s right. I’ve never heard that alias before.”

“If you’re from out of town, that would make sense. Young Master Jin only rose to prominence recently.”

“You mean Young Master Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head?”

“What? Not at all. The Lesser Family Head is impressive too, but the one who played the biggest role this time was Young Master Jin.”

“So that Young Master Jin… Wait. Is the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi somehow related to Third Young Master Jin Taekyung?”

“They’re the same person.”

After a long silence, the man snapped his fingers. A second silver nyang[307] landed perfectly in the storyteller's bowl.

"I believe I asked you to keep it simple and stick to the facts."

"I'll stake my balls on it."

At the storyteller's resolute answer, the man sighed.

"Let's say that's true. What happened to Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

"They're on the verge of closing their gates. Second Young Master Lee Seogeun had already died, and their Sect Leader, Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek, fell in battle. Two days later, even their successor—the First Young Master—was killed fighting a band of mounted bandits."

"Mounted bandits?"

"These gutsy bastards heard the Blood Wolf Sword was dead and stormed Mount Heng Sword Sect. Word is they'd been circling nearby from the start, waiting for their chance."

"What a dog's mess."

"A horse's mess, more like. They're mounted bandits, aren't they?"

The inn went dead quiet. Everyone expected the big-spending martial artist to drive a third silver nyang[308] into the storyteller's forehead.

Instead, the man rose from his seat without a word.

"Thank you for the story."

Even after the man left, the storyteller's tale went on. The patrons drank without pause, and the snacks never ran out.

They all talked about the struggle for supremacy among martial artists. Victory and defeat. The young hero who had risen like a morning star.

"It won't be long before the Jin Family of Taiyuan steps beyond Shanxi and stands tall in the Central Plains. The Lesser Family Head, who excels in both civil and martial arts, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, who rose to prominence this time, and… and who else was it?"

"The Heaven Shaking Sword?"

"Ah, right. Second Young Master Jin Mukyung!"

"That young man is incredible too. They say he's a martial arts genius who appears once in a hundred years, if that."

"But where is he now? What's he doing?"

"Dunno. At this hour, he's probably asleep."

Even as the drinking continued inside the inn, the man rode on in silence. His mouth was shut tight, but his ears remained wide open.

"Did you hear?"

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[307] A silver nyang is a unit of silver currency used in the story's historical setting.

[308] A silver nyang is a unit of silver currency used in the story's historical setting.

"The Sleeping Dragon again? My ears are bleeding. Give it a rest."

"Yeah, but this is top-grade information. I heard it from a martial artist at the Jin Family of Taiyuan's Gate Guard Pavilion."

"What's the fuss?"

"You know the Heavenly Axe?"

"The Heavenly Axe of the Eighteen Strongholds of Green Forest? That mountain bandit who's a Peak master anyway?"

"That's the one. Word is the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi took him out too!"

"Isn't that just a rumor? Why would someone like the Heavenly Axe come all the way to Shanxi Province to play bandit?"

"How would I know? The wilder part is that Yama Whip was there too."

"Yama Whip too?!"

"They say he's disguised as a coachman at Honghwaru. If you ever have reason to go there, watch yourself."

Of all the words in the ceaseless chatter, two came up most often.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

And Jin Taekyung.

The closer the man came to his destination, the more the rumors swelled like a snowball, growing larger and larger.

The most handsome man of all time. Possessor of the heaven-bestowed Heavenly Martial Physique. A chivalrous hero who cannot stand injustice.

The man in the bamboo hat spurred his horse onward. Hearing so much as the *Shan* in Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi made his stomach churn and his head ache as if he had suffered an internal injury.

He finally reached his destination the next morning.

Been a while.

The place he had returned to after several years was unchanged.

If there was any difference worth mentioning—

"Stop right there! I am Hyuk Mujin, Captain of the Gatekeepers of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, hegemon of Shanxi, and right-hand man of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! State your identity and purpose, and—"

—it was that a guy who looked like hell was serving as Captain of the Gatekeepers.

The man in the bamboo hat, Jin Mukyung, sighed.

"Shut up and open the gate."

Whoooosh.

A current flowed, calm and unimpeded.

The internal energy that had left my dantian raced through hundreds of acupoints, then finally returned to its rightful place.

Ding!

SYSTEM

You have successfully circulated your qi.
The realm of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique has risen to the Eighth Stage.

I opened my eyes as I listened to the System notification.

The Eighth Stage.

It was clearly good news, but I couldn't help feeling a little disappointed.

I had been waiting for a different notification.

Could've at least bumped up my internal energy.

Today marked two months since I had gained access to the System. Circulating my qi had become a habit, but my internal energy was still going nowhere.

At this rate, it'll take another ten years.

The greatest strength of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique I had learned was its stability. Unlike ordinary internal cultivation techniques, I could even run it while moving.

The problem was…

It accumulates internal energy slow as fuck.

For a martial artist, lacking internal energy was a fatal weakness.

I could handle First Rate and Second Rate opponents easily enough, but if I ran into a Peak master as an enemy, even two lives wouldn't be enough.

Experiencing the Head Elder's martial might firsthand had driven that home.

That old man was something else.

Even after five days, I still couldn't forget it.

No. Not five days.

Even fifty years from now, I would never forget that sight.

The Sword Energy and Sword Force sweeping across the battlefield. And that absurd number—Level 95.

How long could I have lasted against him one-on-one?

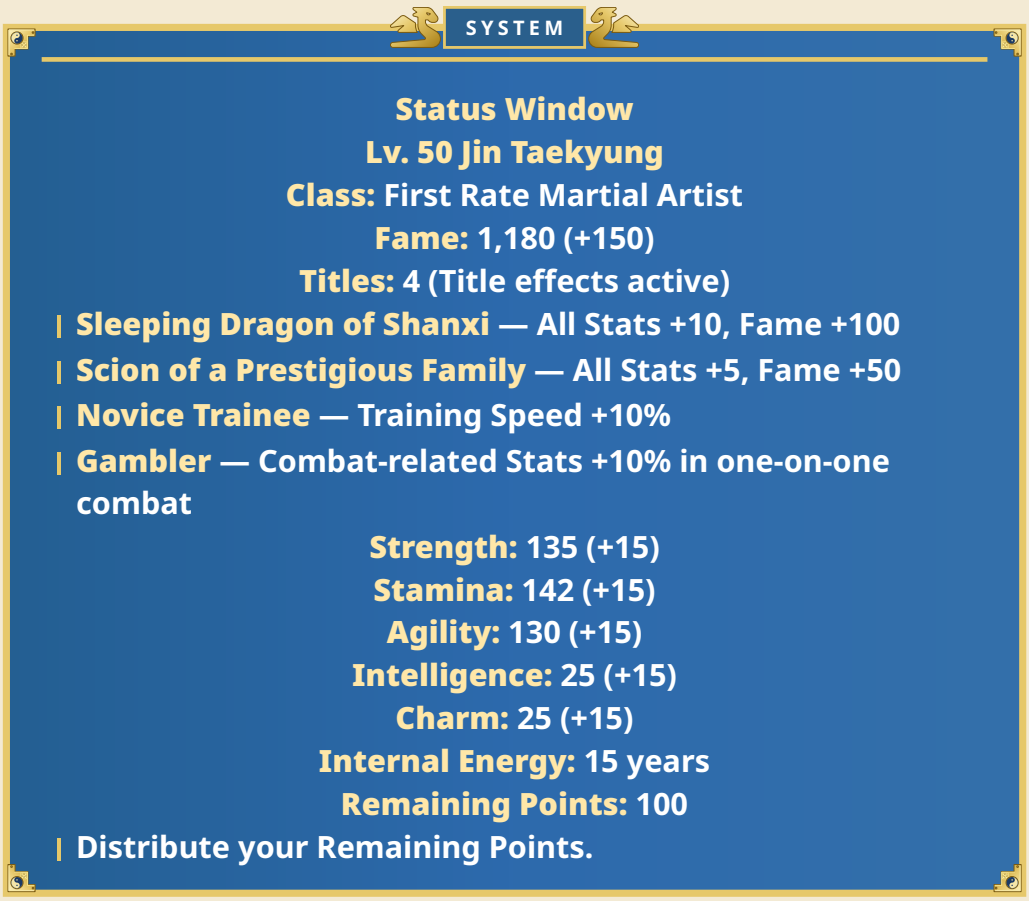
Even if I had wrung out every last ounce of strength, I doubted I could have held on for a full minute.

But unexpected variables had overturned the result, and I had managed to drive my spear through his chest.

And the System had not forgotten my reward.

“Open Status Window.”

Ding!



“Ohhh, yeah.”

I had checked that Status Window dozens of times over the past few days, and I still wasn’t sick of it. It felt like carbonation popping in my veins.

Fighting the Head Elder was worth it.

It had been a gamble with my life on the line, and the reward was just as lavish.

I had jumped thirteen levels in one stroke, my Fame had entered the triple digits, and my Titles had changed.

“Check Titles.”

Ding!

SYSTEM

Status Window
Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi
Grade: Peak
Effect: All Stats +10, Fame +100
Description: Your fame has now spread throughout Shanxi. But the world is vast and masters are many. Never become complacent!

I wasn't a nationwide name yet, but apparently I had some real clout here in my home district of Shanxi…

So that's why it's called the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?

Goyang's Honey Fist. Incheon's Sea of Blood. That kind of thing.

Either way, it was good for me. I had a solid new Title, and Family Shame, the tag that had clung to me until recently, was gone. It felt as good as having an aching tooth pulled.

I've gotten stronger again.

I suddenly remembered my conversation with Team Leader Choi before returning to Murim. I had told him that the next time he saw me, he would have to revise my contract.

He had probably taken it as a bluff. I had made it a fact.

I'll get as strong as I can, then go back.

I would take every scrap of power I could get before I returned.

Internal energy, martial arts, stats. Whatever it was, all of it.

On my next Logout, I'd be a B-rank Hunter—no, an A-rank Hunter—and return home in glory…

"Huh?"

Wait.

I was forgetting something incredibly important.

What is it?

I stopped everything I was doing and tried to pin down that sense of déjà vu.

That was when—

"Is it here?"

"Yessir. No mistake."

Two voices murmured outside the door. The moment I realized one of them belonged to Hyuk Mujin—

Boom!

The door tore off its hinges with a thunderous crash.

I take basic common sense seriously.

Tissues go in the trash. Cigarettes belong in designated smoking areas. Porn comes from Japan.

And when you enter someone else's room, you knock.

I especially believe that anyone who barges into a room occupied by a man alone without knocking deserves life in prison.

"Here you are."

By that standard, the bastard in front of me got the death penalty.

Smashing the door got him life. Talking to me like we were equals on our first meeting earned him an additional sentence.

I answered him politely.

"Yeah. I'm here."

The bastard's eyes went round. His face was black with grime, as if he had spent twenty years in the Aoji Coal Mine.[309]

Young, in shabby clothes. The story practically wrote itself.

Wandering Martial Artist #1.

An extra who had come running after hearing about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

I turned to Hyuk Mujin, who was wearing a similar expression.

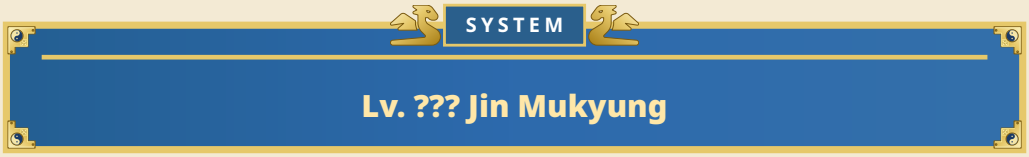
"What's with this guy?"

Hyuk Mujin froze solid. He looked like he had seen a ghost.

"You don't know him?"

"How would I know, idiot? You have to introduce people."

Grumbling, I raised my Qi Sense. A blue circle stretched toward the two of them.



Jin Mukyung. Guess he's pretty high-level.

"Huh? Jin Mukyung?"

I looked at the Level window once.

Then at his face.

I repeated that three or four times before approaching him with my heart pounding.

"Uh. Just a second."

[309] Aoji Coal Mine was a coal mine in North Korea notorious for harsh working conditions.

"…"

Rub, rub.

My clean sleeve turned black. Then a handsome face emerged. I thought I had seen it somewhere before, and then I realized it was the face I saw every morning when I washed up.

We're the spitting image of each other.

Heh.

I gave an awkward laugh. Wandering Martial Artist #1 was glaring at me, his eyes like ice.

"Long time no see, hyung.[310]"

[310] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Chapter 64

Slowly. Don’t rush.

Jin Wikyung steadied his breathing. This was a crucial moment. One mistake could ruin everything.

I’ve done well so far. I just need to keep it up.

A bead of cold sweat slid down his cheek, but Jin Wikyung was concentrating so fiercely that he didn’t even notice.

His pupils contracted. His faint, trembling breath stopped.

Now!

It was the instant Jin Wikyung’s eyes flew open and his hand shot out like lightning.

Bang!

“My lord!”

Wipeng burst into the study amid a thunderous crash and spoke with an urgent expression.

“There’s chaos outside… What’s wrong?”

A trembling voice escaped Jin Wikyung’s lips.

“I was almost finished.”

“What?”

“I poured my heart and soul into it for two shichen.[311] All for this one moment.”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about, but that’s not important right—”

“It is important!”

With a cry that sounded almost like a scream, he tore at his hair.

“It was important! Who are you to decide that?”

Tremble, tremble.

Jin Wikyung looked so sorrowful and full of resentment that Wipeng forgot about the urgent situation and stared at his lord.

I was too hasty.

It had been five days since the war ended. Jin Wikyung had been buried under an unprecedented workload dealing with the aftermath. Of course his nerves were frayed. If Wipeng had driven a normally generous man to such anger, the fault had to be his.

“I apologize. I was in such a hurry that I lost my head.”

Wipeng’s sincere apology softened Jin Wikyung’s anger.

“Please be more careful next time.”

---

[311] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are approximately four hours.

But it did nothing to ease the sorrow saturating his voice. Feeling even guiltier, Wipeng said, “If it’s something I can take care of, let me help.”

“No need. The water’s already spilled. I’ll have to start the drawing over from the beginning.”

“I can draw it for you inst—what?”

Wipeng approached Jin Wikyung with a trembling heart. A huge sheet of paper completely covered the table.

“What is this?”

His voice was drier than desert sand, but Jin Wikyung didn’t notice.

“I tried to capture the battle from five days ago in a painting.”

“Not the battle. The Third Young Master.”

“Same thing. Anyway, it would have been perfect once I finished Taekyung’s eyes…”

“I came in and ruined the brushwork.”

“No. Come to think of it, this is for the best.”

Jin Wikyung sighed.

“Heaven must have refused to let my paltry skill portray Taekyung. Don’t you agree?”

“…”

Wipeng silently picked up the painting.

Rip! Rip-rip-rip!

“No! My *Birth of a Hero*!”

“You even gave it a title?”

Wipeng pressed a hand to his forehead as Jin Wikyung wailed in anguish. Whenever—very, very occasionally—his lord acted like this, Wipeng felt the urge to retire to the countryside.

Should I just open a martial arts school?

Seeing his lord gather up the scraps of paper with a devastated expression made him feel even more desperate to retire.

“I was going to keep it in my private collection!”

“To hell with your private collection—you need to get outside right now.”

“Why?”

“Young Master Jin has returned.”

Jin Wikyung stopped picking up the scraps and tilted his head.

“Did the youngest go somewhere?”

“Not that Young Master Jin.”

At the disbelief in Jin Wikyung’s eyes, Wipeng nodded.

“Yes. The Second Young Master has returned.”

"Mukyung!"

His face lit up. His second younger brother had returned after three years. He wanted to run out and greet him at once.

"All right. Where is he now?"

"At the Third Young Master's residence."

"That Mukyung, who hated the youngest so much, went to find him the moment he arrived? Maybe he's finally going to act like an older brother. He's grown up. Hahaha!"

That was when Jin Wikyung burst into hearty laughter.

Rumble-rumble-rumble.

A sudden thunderous crash shook the estate, followed by screams.

—The building is collapsing! Everyone, get out of the way!

—Get people over here!

—The Third Young Master's residence is collapsiiiing!

Jin Wikyung blinked.

"I think I just heard that the youngest's residence collapsed."

"Brothers grow up by fighting, don't they?"

"What are you talking about… Don't tell me—"

"It's nothing. Just draw a new one."

Wipeng answered with an expression of enlightenment and spread a fresh sheet of paper over the study table.

"I think you should call this one *The Hero Getting Beaten Like a Dog by His Second Brother*."

Whoooosh!

Using a Peak movement technique, Jin Wikyung dashed away like the wind. Wipeng watched his back disappear and sighed.

Should I really open a martial arts school?

His worries had only been growing lately.

Jin Mukyung.

Twenty-three years old. Known by the epithet Heaven Shaking Sword.

A martial arts genius who had reached the Peak realm at barely twenty.

But more important than that was the fact that he was this body's—Jin Taekyung's—second older brother. So, naturally, I was curious.

"I can't remember what Jin Mukyung—or rather, my second brother—was like."

Amnesia was an excellent excuse. When I asked Jin Wikyung that question, he told me everything about him.

"You won't be able to see him right away. He's very far away."

"Where is he?"

"At Heaven's Gate Temple in Henan. That heartless brat hasn't shown his face once in three years."

Despite his words, Jin Wikyung had looked proud.

Like a parent whose child had gotten into Harvard.

"What's his personality like?"

"Hmm. He's kind. People often misunderstand him, but he's definitely a good kid."

"Were we close?"

"…You were. I think you were? Yes, you were close."

"Ah. Right."

I hadn't thought much of it at the time. Once I learned how far Henan was from the Jin Family of Taiyuan, I lost interest altogether.

What, was I seriously going to still be in Murim by then?

It was a distance that required several weeks of nonstop travel on horseback.

That was also why Jin Mukyung hadn't shown so much as the tip of his nose before the war ended. And yet…

I never expected to meet him like this.

His appearance had caught me completely off guard.

I gave him an awkward smile and held out my hand.

"Long time no see, hyung.[312]"

The "hyung"[313] who had been gazing at me steadily took my hand.

"Yes. It's been a long time."

This guy seems nicer than I expected.

Just as Jin Wikyung had said, people must have misunderstood him because of his fierce eyes.

Thinking that eased my tension, and I was able to smile more naturally.

"How've you been?"

Jin Mukyung gave me a faint smile in return.

"Well enough. But, youngest."

"Yeah?"

"Your speech has gotten casual."

Whoom!

The next thing I knew, I was flying toward the wall. Jin Mukyung had hurled me with tremendous force.

What the hell?

---

[312] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older male.

[313] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older male.

I twisted my body in midair. Then I lightly stepped off the wall and landed on the ground. Jin Mukyung watched me and gave a quiet snort.

“Well, well.”

I didn’t like where this was going.

I scratched the back of my head.

“Weren’t we close?”

“We were. My fist and your body.”

“Ah.”

I was insane to believe Jin Wikyung. The man doted on his younger brothers like his life depended on it.

Shit. He should’ve explained that properly.

Jin Mukyung held out his fist.

“This is your oldest friend. Say hello.”

“Hello.”

Ominously, his smile widened.

“Our youngest has grown a lot. Acting cocky in front of your big brother.”

Whoooosh!

Jin Mukyung charged like lightning and threw a punch. The air tore before his fist.

He’s serious?

The blow carried no internal energy, but the raw force behind it was immense.

I jerked my head aside in alarm.

Bang!

The wooden wall exploded. Fists rained down through the splinters scattering in the air.

Bababang!

Face, chest, shoulder, stomach.

The punches seemed wild and random, but his movements flowed smoothly, and the area they covered was as tightly woven as a net.

“A fist technique?”

“Been a while since you had a taste of the Reformation Fist, hasn’t it?”

Fuck, what kind of name is that for a fist technique?

As I cursed inwardly, a move from the Reformation Fist slammed into my abdomen.

Whump!

“Hup.”

“It’s not over yet.”

I fought through the breath-stealing pain and blocked the incoming punch with my forearm. The dull impact made my bones throb.

"You blocked?"

Bababababam!

It hurt. It hurt like hell.

Jin Mukyung outclassed me in every way—strength, speed, everything.

But how should I put it…

This is more manageable than I expected.

Was it because he wasn't using internal energy?

At first, all I could do was take a one-sided beating. But after a while, his attacks slowly began to come into focus.

Whoosh!

Jin Mukyung's fist sliced through empty air. A precise read. A clean dodge.

He looked at me in surprise.

"You've improved quite a bit."

I steadied my breathing and grinned.

Since things had come to this, I figured we might as well have a satisfying fight.

"Not quite a bit. A lot. Haven't you heard the rumors?"

"I have. Until I'm sick of them."

Jin Mukyung gave a quiet laugh.

"Then prove how much of them is true."

Shwaaak!

With a sharp sound of air being split, his hand shot toward my wrist.

Like hell!

I widened my eyes and slapped the incoming hand away.

Or tried to.

Tap, tat-tat-tat!

Five attacks and defenses passed between us in less than a second. Then the match was decided in an instant.

Clamp!

"What the hell is this pathetic grappling technique?"

Jin Mukyung finally twisted my wrist into a lock with a strange movement, then spoke as though I were hopeless.

Being caught so helplessly already had me seething, but his next words set my chest on fire.

"Again."

"…What are you trying to do?"

"I already knew the rumors were nonsense. Now I need to correct the habits of a little brother who doesn't know his place."

Jin Mukyung released my wrist and crooked a finger.

“Come at me. I won’t go easy on you this time.”

I stared at him in silence.

Jin Mukyung was unquestionably a master far beyond me. The wall of the Peak realm was too high for my current abilities to overcome.

I knew that. I knew all of it.

This is pissing me off.

And suddenly, I was curious.

How far could I go?

Just how strong was Jin Mukyung, the genius whose reputation had spread so far?

This was competitive pride—not as a Hunter, but as a martial artist of Murim.

Let’s do this.

Jin Mukyung was the first to notice the change in me.

“I didn’t know you could make a face like that.”

“This is my normal face.”

He laughed as though he found it amusing.

“Fine. That’s all well and good… but are you still talking so casually?”

At that moment, Jin Mukyung’s fist blurred.

Whoosh! Whump!

My vision flashed. Even though I had been concentrating to the extreme, I hadn’t managed to avoid the attack completely.

Jin Mukyung looked from his fist to me and back again.

“That shouldn’t have happened.”

The punch had been aimed at my temple. If it had landed cleanly, that would have been the last blow.

Even though he hadn’t used internal energy, I had managed to partially evade a Peak master’s full-powered One Strike.

“See? I’ve improved a lot.”

“I admit it. But you’re not even a quarter as good as the rumors claim.”

“Don’t worry. I’ll catch up little by little from here on.”

“You’ll catch up to me? How long do you think that’ll take?”

I answered.

“Starting this very moment.”

“Hold out for a quarter of an hour. Then you’re my big brother.”

Jin Mukyung’s form blurred once again. But this time, I was a step faster.

Assign ten points to Agility.

Ten level-ups gained through the war. A hundred points lying dormant in my Status Window.

Some of them answered my command.

Shwaaaak!
The change was instantaneous. At the same time, certainty filled me.
I could perfectly evade Jin Mukyung’s fist as it flew toward my face.
Whoosh!
Too slow.
Without hesitation, I turned my head.
Whump!
…Damn it. I should’ve used ten more points.

Chapter 65

Jin Mukyung wondered.

What happened over the past three years?

He hadn't felt this bewildered in a long time, and with every passing moment, his bewilderment snowballed.

Whoosh!

Boom! Crash!

The air exploded. The bedroom furniture—and even the walls—shattered to pieces.

But that was all. Jin Taekyung was narrowly dodging every one of his attacks.

He's dodging this? That guy?

Mukyung could hardly believe his eyes.

Jin Mukyung knew Jin Taekyung well. A scion of a martial family in name only, he was a pathetically weak man in both mind and body.

Mukyung had been willing to overlook it when they were snot-nosed children, but Taekyung's behavior had only grown more absurd with each passing year.

I used to wonder how someone like that could possibly be my little brother.

Had Taekyung been fifteen? Mukyung still remembered the day he brought a chair to the training hall with perfect clarity.

"Little brother, what's that?"

"A chair."

"You left off the last syllable."[314]

"A chair, sir…"

"Why did you bring it?"

"To use during horse-stance training."[315]

"Ah. Because horse stance is too hard?"

That groundbreaking idea had made Jin Mukyung smack his forehead.

At the same time, he had attained enlightenment.

Ah. Words won't work on this one.

"Get down."

And so the Reformation Fist had been born.

And now that same guy is what? The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?

---

[314] In Korean, adding *yo* to an answer makes it polite. Mukyung is demanding that Taekyung address his older brother respectfully.

[315] Horse stance is a martial-arts training posture held with the legs spread and knees bent.

When Mukyung first heard the story at an inn, it was so ridiculous that he couldn't even bring himself to snort. If the storyteller had been twenty years younger, Mukyung would have beaten him senseless.

That was also why he had gone straight to Taekyung's room as soon as he arrived at the family.

Has he gone so far as to fabricate rumors now?

It was obviously the Three Calamities Sword Technique. Mukyung could already picture the whole thing.

The only thing Taekyung knew how to do was chase women. He must have decided he wanted a taste of fame and started pretending to be a Peak master.

You're in for it today.

He had barged in with exactly that attitude.

But then…

He's different.

Mukyung had realized it the instant he saw Taekyung.

His bones and muscles had grown larger and harder. Deep within eyes that still looked like those of a Third Rate wastrel, there was a sharp, piercing aura.

The hand they clasped afterward was rough and strong.

Peak? No. Not yet. He's still Supreme First Rate.

Mukyung knew because he had already walked that path himself. Jin Taekyung was still unrefined. He merely stood before the wall of the Peak realm.

That made it all the more astonishing.

How on earth?

Water and sunlight alone did not make everything grow. Just as a sprout needed spring to emerge, there was a proper time to learn martial arts.

Jin Taekyung had been born with a decent physique, as befitted the bloodline of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, but he had squandered those years and missed his chance.

And yet that same man had grown this much in only three years.

Unless he's undergone Bone Transformation…[316]

Whoosh!

The sharp sound of splitting air shattered Jin Mukyung's thoughts. He narrowly avoided Taekyung's fist, his face hardening.

He's getting faster.

It wasn't his imagination. The more time passed, the faster Taekyung became.

Whoosh!

Even now.

[316] Bone Transformation is an advanced bodily transformation in martial-arts fiction.

Thud!

Jin Mukyung raised an arm to block the attack, and his feelings were nothing but bewilderment. Watching him, Jin Taekyung snickered.

“You didn’t think you could dodge that, did you? That’s why you blocked.”

“You…”

“I told you. I’m catching up.”

“What happened to you? Did you drink *gongcheong seokyu*[317] or something?”

“Why would I drink oil? You’re completely insane.”

“…”

Jin Mukyung trembled at the first verbal abuse he had ever heard in his life.

Who was he? A youthful Peak master and a martial-arts genius! Even the scions of prestigious families throughout the Central Plains who envied him would never dare speak to him so rudely.

And yet his own younger brother, only three years apart in age, had called him a crazy bastard.

“You’re dead.”

Jin Taekyung had flinched for a moment at the ominous aura, but then he let out a quiet laugh.

“Getting pretty casual, aren’t you?”

“What?”

“Didn’t you say that if I lasted a quarter of an hour, I’d be your hyung[318]? It’s been a quarter of an hour. Right, Mujin?”

Hyuk Mujin, crumpled in a corner and barely able to breathe, cautiously answered.

“Yes, I think it probably has.”

But when he saw Jin Mukyung glaring at him as though he meant to kill him, he answered again, nearly in tears.

“Though maybe not… Could I just go outside?”

“No.”

Jin Mukyung muttered the word in a sinister voice and drew up his internal energy.

The aura of a Peak master pressed down on the air. Cracks split the floor, and the atmosphere swelled as though it might burst.

Gr-r-rk.

The smile vanished from Jin Taekyung’s face.

---

[317] *Gongcheong seokyu* is a rare martial-arts elixir; *seokyu* is also the Korean word for petroleum.

[318] *Hyung* is a man’s term of address for an older brother or an older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

"Hyung-nim[319]. I don't think that's quite fair."

In contrast, a broad smile filled Jin Mukyung's face.

"Just keep doing what you were doing, you little bastard."

Bang! Cra-crash!

A deafening roar.

Then, collapse.

Jin Wikyung arrived too late and dropped to his knees before the ruined pavilion.

"Youngest—!"

Rustle. Thump!

At that moment, someone emerged through the wreckage. Wearing a wind cloak, he tossed out a shapeless lump like a piece of luggage. It was impossible to tell whether it was alive or dead.

"He's not dead yet."

After thinking for a moment, he continued.

"One of them might be dead."

As if answering him, a groan rose from the pile of rubble.

"Ghhhh…"

"That's the Captain of the Gatekeepers!"

"Save him! Take him to the Medicine King Hall!"

Looking refreshed, Jin Mukyung gazed up at the sky.

"Ah. Beautiful weather."

A rude younger brother needed a good beating now and then.

The distinctive smell of medicinal herbs stung my nose. I slowly opened my eyes.

The room had been cleaned up. A dozen or so people hurried back and forth outside the door, and Hyuk Mujin lay asleep in the bed beside mine, swathed in bandages.

The Medicine King Hall.

At this point, it was practically my second home. Come to think of it, I had probably woken up here more often than I had in my own pavilion.

Oh, right. The pavilion had collapsed too.

Great.

"Goddammit."

That ignorant bastard, Jin Mukyung. Where was I supposed to sleep now?

As I stared blankly at the ceiling, something began squirming beneath my blanket.

[319] *Hyung* is a man's term of address for an older brother or an older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

What the hell is this?

I lifted the blanket, revealing a small, round, white life-form clinging tightly to my side.

A brief silence passed before I opened my mouth.

“What are you doing here?”

“Shh! Quiet! Quiet!”

It was Soyul, Socheon’s little sister. The five-year-old stared at me with the most desperate eyes in the world.

“What are you doing?”

“Be quiet!”

“Your voice is the loudest one here.”

“Shh!”

Whatever she was doing, she certainly knew how to live an interesting life.

I sighed and pulled the blanket back over us. That lasted only a moment.

Squirm, squirm.

“Pwah!”

Soyul poked her face out and huffed.

“I can’t breathe!”

Was this really the Medicine King Hall? Could just anyone wander in and out of a patient’s room while he was supposed to be resting?

“Are you sorry or not!”

She tapped my chest with her tiny hands, and her expression was surprisingly stern.

“All right. So what were you doing here?”

“Playing hide-and-seek.”

“With whom?”

“With my big brother!”

Soyul smiled sweetly.

“He’ll never dream I hid here!”

“We’ll see.”

I glanced at the closed door. I had sensed someone hovering outside for a while now. It was obvious who it was.

“Come in.”

“…”

“It’s all right. Come in.”

Only then did the door cautiously open. Looking deeply humbled, Socheon said,

“Please excuse the intrusion, Benefactor.”

At the appearance of her brother, Soyul stared at me in shock.

“You betrayed me!”

I answered with a benevolent smile.

“Life is a series of betrayals.”

“That doesn’t count! It was a dirty conspiracy!”

“Where did you learn words like that?”

At the sight of his five-year-old sister showing off such sinister vocabulary, Socheon’s face turned red.

“Yul, you mustn’t say things like that!”

“Big brother’s a whole heap too!”

“You mean he’s in on it.”

At this point, any chance of getting some rest had gone out the window.

Suppressing a sigh, I sat up.

“Urgh.”

“Benefactor, are you all right? You haven’t recovered yet…”

“It’s not that bad. I’m just bruised.”

I had been beaten a little—or rather, quite a lot—but all that had happened was that my bones ached and my entire body was covered in bruises.

Jin Mukyung must have held back because I was his only younger brother. I’d counted on that, which was why I’d acted so recklessly.

“Oh, I see. That’s a relief.”

“But how did you know? Have the rumors already spread?”

“Everyone in the family knows.”

Naturally. A two-story pavilion had collapsed early in the morning.

Curious to hear what was being said, I asked,

“So what are people saying?”

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi got beaten like a dog by the Heaven Shaking Sword. Turns out he was nothing but hype.

Surely rumors like that had spread everywhere.

I can already see it…

“Everyone is furious. What a treacherous scheme!”

“Huh?”

A treacherous scheme? What was he talking about? Had Jin Mukyung used poison without my knowing? Had I been poisoned?

As I searched my memory in bewilderment, Socheon ground his teeth, his face full of rage.

“If he had crossed my path, I would have torn him apart, even if it meant dying with him.”

“Thanks for caring, but isn’t that a little excessive? Calm down. Seriously, calm down.”

Jin Mukyung probably wouldn’t simply laugh that off if he heard it.

But despite my attempts to stop him, Socheon’s anger did not subside.

“How could I? The Lesser Family Head himself has proclaimed the man’s immediate execution.”

“…”

What the hell? That’s terrifying.

Was this the kind of place where the second son got the death penalty for hitting his youngest brother?

Is this what Murim is like?

I asked in a trembling voice.

“Did they kill him?”

Socheon shook his head regretfully.

“He escaped. The pursuit team should be tracking his trail by now.”

“Are you kidding me?”

They had even formed a pursuit team. I barely restrained the urge to split open Jin Wikyung’s and Socheon’s heads and inspect their brains.

“Was all that really necessary?”

“Pardon?”

“I mean, the guy was a little rough with me, but he didn’t seem like such a bad person.”

“He tried to harm you, Benefactor!”

“That happens. I understand.”

I had a younger sister too, so I knew how it was. Sometimes I wished Hayeon had been a younger brother. If she were some hulking bastard of a man, I could beat him half to death without worrying about social criticism or pangs of conscience.

“Look. I’m barely hurt. Spit on it, give me a day or two of rest, and I’ll be completely fine.”

Socheon’s eyes trembled violently.

“Benefactor… You are truly a *junzi*.[320] I, Socheon, am sincerely moved.”

Thump.

This was driving me crazy.

I pressed a hand to my forehead as Socheon abruptly dropped into a full bow.

“Enough. Go tell them to call off the pursuit. No—going myself would be faster. Where’s my eldest brother?”

Socheon immediately answered.

[320] A *junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

“He should be in the office with the Second Young Master.”

“Huh?”

“Pardon?”

“No, what did you say?”

“The Lesser Family Head is in the office with the Second Young Master.”

My thoughts became tangled. I barely managed to speak.

“Then who is the pursuit team chasing?”

Socheon tilted his head.

“The assassin, of course.”

“An assassin?”

“What assassin?”

Another voice suddenly cut in. Hyuk Mujin had woken up and spoke in a tone that clearly meant *What kind of bullshit is this?*

“What is he talking about?”

I ignored Hyuk Mujin and gestured for Socheon to continue.

“For now, we suspect he may be the Head Elder’s hidden disciple. His martial arts were so formidable that if the Second Young Master hadn’t happened to arrive, you would have suffered a grave calamity… Isn’t that right?”

Hyuk Mujin’s mouth fell open at the unbelievable story.

“Are you crazy? Do you want me to tell you why I ended up like this?”

Just as the shrimp whose back had been broken in the fight between two whales was about to tell the truth, Socheon spoke up.

“Ah, I left out Warrior Hyuk. I heard that you fought bravely against the assassin.”

Hyuk Mujin’s ears perked up.

“Me? Who said that?”

“The Lesser Family Head. You distinguished yourself in battle this time, and you were badly injured while protecting the Benefactor. Everyone is envious, saying your reward will be enormous. They say you’re a shoo-in to become the next Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion.”

“T-The next Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion!”

“But what were you going to tell us?”

“That…”

Hyuk Mujin flinched for a moment, then continued in a resolute voice.

“About the assassin.”

“Oooooh!”

“He was strong. Even I, the next Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion, fought him for a hundred-odd exchanges without settling the match…”

What a bumper crop of bullshit.

Chapter 66

Step. Step.

Each time the young man took a step, people hurriedly moved aside.

His sculpted, handsome features played a part, but it was the intense presence radiating from him that overwhelmed them.

He stood out even from a distance.

“Wow, he’s handsome.”

At the thoughtless remark from a maid who had joined the household the previous year, an old servant gave a quiet laugh.

“Stop dreaming.”

“Who said I was? I’ve just never seen him before.”

“Didn’t you see him earlier, when the Third Young Master’s pavilion collapsed?”

“With all that chaos, do you think I only saw one or two people? Still, I don’t think I could forget that man even if I’d seen him in the middle of a war. Hehe.”

“True. He was in quite a state back then.”

The maid thought for a moment, then her eyes widened.

“Oh, don’t tell me…”

“That’s right. He’s the Second Young Master. So stop dreaming and get back to work.”

Jin Mukyung ignored the whispers around him and continued on with an indifferent expression.

When he reached the stately, old-fashioned pavilion, the martial artists guarding the entrance opened the doors for him. The looks of awe were a bonus.

“The Lesser Family Head is waiting for you.”

“Thank you.”

The moment Jin Mukyung entered the Lesser Family Head’s office, he was greeted by the rich scent of tea—and by his older brother, Jin Wikyung, charging toward him with heavy, pounding footsteps.

“Little brother!”

Jin Wikyung threw his arms wide and pulled Jin Mukyung into a tight embrace.

For a moment, Mukyung considered dodging. But if he did, he would have to watch that hulking man whine like a child.

“I can’t breathe.”

His tone was as stiff as a wooden puppet’s.

“Is that what you say to your brother after not seeing him for three years?”

“I would say the same if it had been thirty.”

“You’ve grown cold. You’ve changed so much.”

“Yes. I’m a cold-blooded man without blood or tears.”

“That’s all right. I naturally run hot.”

“…Let go.”

A short while later, the two brothers sat across from each other and began to talk.

“I don’t see Sir Wipeng.”

Wipeng, who should have been at the Lesser Family Head’s side like a shadow, was nowhere to be seen.

Jin Wikyung took a sip of tea before answering.

“I put him in charge of a pursuit team and sent him out. It’ll take at least half a month to go all the way to Three Questions Gorge and back.”

“That far?”

If Taiyuan, where the family was based, lay at the heart of Shanxi, Three Questions Gorge was practically its gateway and outermost edge. It was also a crossroads leading to Shaanxi and Henan, so even fifteen days would be a tight schedule.

“It’s only a formality anyway. Aren’t you putting him through too much?”

“Why? Feeling sorry for him?”

“I didn’t expect things to get this big.”

“Neither did I. I didn’t expect you to cause such an incident the moment you arrived.”

“That’s not—”

“Mukyung.”

Unlike before, Jin Wikyung’s eyes held a light reproach. Jin Mukyung sighed.

“I didn’t intend to take it that far. At first, I only meant to exchange a few moves.”

“And then?”

“He was pretty good. I got heated and used too much force.”

“Of course you did. He wasn’t the youngest brother you remembered.”

Jin Mukyung nodded reluctantly.

He had traded blows with Jin Taekyung himself only a shichen or two earlier.[321] He could no longer deny it.

“Since we’re on the subject, what on earth happened?”

“The youngest?”

“Everything. The letter I received only said that the Mount Heng Sword Sect bastards were invading.”

A messenger eagle had been dispatched immediately after the Mount Heng Sword Sect declared war, so there had been no way for him to learn the details.

All he knew were the rumors he had heard on his way to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

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[321] A *shichen* is a traditional unit of time equal to approximately two hours.

“Is it true that the Head Elder betrayed us?”

“Yes. It’s a long story.”

“How long?”

“It goes back forty years, to the Great Faction War.”

Jin Wikyung’s expression hardened as he began to speak.

“Then never mind.”

“Back then, the Head Elder… What did you say?”

“Never mind. It’s already over. What good would hearing about it do me?”

Jin Mukyung nonchalantly drained his tea in one gulp, and Jin Wikyung’s face filled with disbelief.

“You little bastard!”

This was the family’s hidden history, after all. Jin Mukyung had always cared about nothing but martial arts, but Jin Wikyung had never imagined he could be this bad.

“You need to know! You’re a direct descendant of our family—”

“The Head Elder betrayed us. Then he died. The Mount Heng Sword Sect was destroyed in the process. The Jin Family of Taiyuan was the final victor. Did I misunderstand anything?”

“No, that’s right, but…”

Jin Wikyung began to wonder which of them was the abnormal one.

Then he suddenly remembered something.

“You were the one who asked me to tell you everything!”

“Ah, I take that back. If I listen to things that happened before I was even born, I’ll grow old and die right here. I’d rather spend that time swinging my sword one more time.”

“…”

“Then I’ll be going.”

“You’re leaving? Where?”

“To train, obviously.”

“T-Training? Now?”

“I came hoping to spar with Sir Wipeng after so long, but he isn’t here. Shouldn’t I train alone, at least?”

Jin Wikyung was speechless.

Is that how a younger brother is supposed to act after seeing his older brother for the first time in three years?

His heart ached with betrayal.

“Mukyung!”

Jin Mukyung answered the heartfelt call coldly.

“Thank you for the tea.”

He left the office without even looking back.

Jin Wikyung stared at the back of his departing younger brother, stunned.

After everything I did to raise you…

Both his second and youngest brothers had grown up so fast. He was proud of the fine men they had become, but sometimes, moments like this still left him feeling hurt.

Yes. I suppose this is the natural order of things.

Jin Wikyung let out a sigh deep enough to sink the earth, then sat at his worktable.

He carefully began piecing together the ill-fated masterpiece that had been torn apart earlier: *The Birth of a Hero*.

“We haven’t found a single trace.”

“He left behind no witnesses or footprints. He’s an elusive bastard.”

At his subordinate’s report, Wipeng swallowed a bitter smile.

There had never been an assassin in the first place. Naturally, there were no traces to find.

I have to put on an act I was never meant to perform.

The conversation he had shared with Jin Wikyung a shichen earlier flashed through his mind.[322]

“An assassin? Haven’t you made this affair too big?”

“An opportunity has presented itself. We have to use it.”

“You don’t mean the opportunity to rebuild the Third Young Master’s pavilion even more lavishly, do you?”

“Oh, that’s a good idea. Make it happen.”

“My lord!”

“I’m joking. Just joking.”

“Then what opportunity are you talking about?”

That was when the smile disappeared from his lord’s face.

“An opportunity for our family to encompass all of Shanxi Province.”

“…!”

“I spent the past five days searching through every record in the family. There was a name I needed to find. You know what it is, don’t you?”

“Dark Heaven.”

“Aren’t you curious about the result?”

“You didn’t find it.”

[322] A *shichen* is a traditional unit of time equal to approximately two hours.

“Clouds are gathering. Clouds that have never shown themselves before. We need to prepare before they appear.”

“Give me your orders.”

“I’ll assign thirty elites to you. Head south immediately. The official objective is to capture or kill the assassin, but your true mission is something else.”

Wipeng unconsciously touched his chest. His fingers brushed against the thick bundle of papers Jin Wikyung had handed him.

“What is this?”

“On the coming New Year’s Day, I intend to summon every sect in Shanxi Province to our family.”

This was no invitation. It was a summons.

Wipeng was not foolish enough to misunderstand what that meant.

“Are you trying to become the Alliance Leader?”

“If necessary.”

Until recently, Shanxi Murim had appeared to the outside world to be divided between two towering peaks: the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

But the reality was different. Shanxi Murim was more like a three-legged cauldron.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan, the Mount Heng Sword Sect, and the smaller sects.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan held the central region, while the Mount Heng Sword Sect held the north. The south belonged to more than twenty small and mid-sized sects.

The Five Gates of Shanxi, which had vanished in the recent war, was merely the name given to the five especially powerful sects among them.

“Their alliance is strong. They may refuse to comply.”

“They might have, before the war.”

The three-legged cauldron had begun to tip.

And the Jin Family of Taiyuan had both the strength and the justification to support Shanxi Murim’s cauldron alone.

“Can you do it?”

The answer had already been decided.

Wipeng muttered in a low voice.

“I shall obey.”

At that same moment, Jin Wikyung was piecing together *The Birth of a Hero* and cursing Wipeng.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv.50 Jin Taekyung
Job: First Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 1,180 (+150)
Titles: 4 (Title effects active)
- **Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi** (All Stats +10, Fame +100)
- **Scion of a Prestigious Family** (All Stats +5, Fame +50)
- **Novice Trainee** (Training speed +10%)
- **Gambler** (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one combat)

Strength: 135 (+15)
Stamina: 142 (+15)
Agility: 180 (+15)
Intelligence: 25 (+15)
Charm: 25 (+15)
Internal Energy: 15 years
Remaining Points: 50
- Distribute your remaining points.

I stared at the Status Window in regret.

Damn it. I spent too many points.

While fighting Jin Mukyung, I had dumped a full fifty points into Agility. The balance between my stats, which I had worked so hard to maintain, was ruined. Of course I was bitter about it.

I thought twenty or thirty points at most would be enough.

A Peak master was a high wall to overcome.

No—maybe Jin Mukyung was simply even stronger than I had expected. People didn't get called geniuses for nothing.

"When I held out for fifty exchanges, even the assassin was visibly flustered. Until recently, I had devoted myself solely to training, so I was an unknown master whose name had yet to spread through Shanxi—"

Smack!

"Ghk!"

Hyuk Mujin, who had been struck on the back of the head, let out a scream.

"What was that for?"

"Stop filling the kids' heads with nonsense. Unless you want to croak."

But Socheon was waiting for the rest of the story with shining eyes.

"I'm fine."

"What does 'croak' mean? Soyul wants to croak too!"

"…You've still got a long time before that."

I stroked Soyul's head as she tugged on my sleeve and pestered me.

My connection with these little siblings had grown fairly deep. As I watched them quietly, someone suddenly came to mind.

"How is Great Hero Gong these days?"

Gong Yacheong—the middle-aged man Socheon and Soyul called Uncle.

Murim terminology still felt awkward to me, but I always made sure to call Gong Yacheong Great Hero Gong. He deserved the title.

"He's recovering smoothly. He still has trouble moving around, though."

"Really? That's good to hear."

"He said he would like to see you before he leaves."

I was about to nod without thinking when I stopped.

"Before he leaves?"

"Yes. He'll be put in charge of the Sakju Branch, which is being rebuilt this time."

"Then…"

"We've decided to go with him."

War took many things away.

Socheon and Soyul had lost both their home and their parents in the Mount Heng Sword Sect's attack. They could not turn back the years that had passed, but now that everything had been settled, they would return to the place steeped in precious memories.

"Thank you for everything, Benefactor."

The sincerity in his farewell made something tickle in a corner of my chest. There was still a reality far too cruel for these young siblings to bear.

What was worse, Soyul did not even know that her parents were dead.

She's five…

She was far too young to recognize and accept the present.

I tried to recall a memory from twenty-two years ago.

It was hazy.

"…I hope it's the same for you, too."

Soyul smiled shyly at the words she did not understand.

I turned toward Socheon.

"Can I come visit you from time to time?"

Socheon beamed as if he had been waiting for me to ask.

"You're always welcome, Benefactor."

Hyuk Mujin, who had been listening quietly, broke through the warm atmosphere between us.

"Then when are you leaving?"

“Half a year from now.”

“…”

There went my touching moment. I should’ve saved it.

Chapter 67

“Ugh, every bone in my body aches.”

Hyuk Mujin groaned. His exposed upper body was stained dark reddish-black all over.

At the sight, the crotchety-looking old man—the Medicine King Hall Master—clicked his tongue.

“What the hell did you do to your body?”

He untied the bundle he had brought with him, revealing acupuncture needles as thick as stakes. Hyuk Mujin asked in a terrified voice, “You’re going to stick those in me?”

“What, scared?”

“They look like they’ll hurt like hell… Please go easy on me.”

“Sure, why not.”

The Medicine King Hall Master answered readily and took out two large needles.

“I’ll put one in the Baihui Acupoint at the crown of your head and one in the Huiyin Acupoint at your perineum. If you die, you won’t have to worry about pain anymore.”

“…”

“Now you’re finally ready to be treated.”

After silencing Hyuk Mujin with a single sentence, the Medicine King Hall Master got to work. In the blink of an eye, dozens of large and small needles pierced Hyuk Mujin’s skin.

Thuk-thuk-thuk.

“Argh! Argh!”

“A young punk like you, making such a fuss. From the sound of that voice, you’ll be hale and hearty for another fifty years.”

Leaving Hyuk Mujin, who had turned into a porcupine, behind, the Medicine King Hall Master turned to me.

“Strip.”

“What, what?”

“Are you deaf? Take off your shirt.”

When it came to age, to hell with being the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi or anything else. I shot a sidelong glance at the blue-glinting needles and took off my top.

Rustle.

“Hm?”

The Medicine King Hall Master’s eyes widened when he saw my body.

“What the hell are you?”

His voice was full of astonishment, and understandably so. Until yesterday, my body had been covered in bruises, but now it was clean.

I didn't expect this much either.

After a single night's sleep, most of the bruises had disappeared, and even my aching bones felt perfectly fine.

Is this the power of Sleep Mode?

It seemed that simply sleeping now let me recover quickly from most ordinary bruises. Even the Medicine King Hall Master, a physician seasoned by years of experience, found me fascinating and examined me for quite some time.

"Did you take an elixir last night?"

"No. I just circulated my qi all day and got a good night's sleep."

"Is it the effect of the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng? No, that's too much…"

The Medicine King Hall Master glared at me suspiciously, as if wondering whether I had raided the medicine storeroom again, then shook his head.

"The Third Young Master may be discharged."

Hyuk Mujin, who had been groaning, brightened.

"What about me? What about me?"

"I swear, if you run off again without permission, I'll ram one of these needles into your Huiyin Acupoint."

The gaunt old man muttered in a sinister voice, jabbing a large needle through the air. He looked like something straight out of a horror movie.

That'll be one bloody opening ceremony.

"Third Young Master, get out. Unless you want the needles too."

Thanks…

That was the moment I jumped to my feet to escape those eyes gleaming with madness.

A sudden flash of insight crossed my mind.

Where am I supposed to go now?

The pavilion had collapsed, leaving me with nowhere to return to. I had become homeless overnight, and as I stood there hesitating—

"Ahem. Medicine King Hall Master, are you inside?"

A familiar voice came from beyond the door. Wondering if it could really be him, I opened it and found exactly the face I had expected.

"Hyung?"[323]

Jin Wikyung jumped a beat too late.

[323] Hyung is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

“No, what are you doing here? I came because I had something urgent to discuss with the Medicine King Hall Master during my duties. What an incredible coincidence!”

“…”

Nice try.

After hearing about my situation, Jin Wikyung led the way with a solemn expression.

“I know of a place you can use as a residence for a while. Follow me.”

He was clearly conscious of the people watching us. After all, the image he had built over the years was that of a coolheaded, capable Lesser Family Head who kept public and private matters strictly separate.

The problem was…

“It’s the Lesser Family Head.”

“Isn’t that the Third Young Master beside him? What are those two doing together in broad daylight?”

“Maybe he can’t bear to be apart from him for even a moment. You know how he dotes on the Third Young Master.”

Anyone who paid attention already knew: Jin Wikyung was a complete fool for his little brother.

Of course they did. Anyone who didn’t know would be the abnormal one.

He was still like this in his mid-thirties. I could only imagine how bad he had been when he was younger. Right after the battle, he had even been so overcome with joy that he carried me around on his shoulders.

“My youngest! My little brother!”

After making such a spectacle in front of hundreds of people, there was no way anyone could have missed it.

As I sighed inwardly, a thread of Sound Transmission slipped into my ear.

“How was that? Hyung[324] can act too, huh?”

I nodded. If there were an Academy Award for terrible acting, he might have had a shot at Best Actor.

“Are you all right? Mukyung didn’t do it out of malice, so I hope you’ll understand.”

“…”

His fists had been overflowing with malice. It was only thanks to my rapid recovery that I hadn’t spent several days staring at the Medicine King Hall ceiling.

[324] Hyung is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

I should avoid running into him whenever possible.

That kid had a nasty temper, and the martial arts to back it up. There was no dealing with him.

The moment Jin Mukyung appeared, he had shot straight to the top of my internal watch list.

"Still, see him often enough and you'll grow fond of him."

See him often enough and I'll grow black-and-blue.

Oblivious to my thoughts, Jin Wikyung laughed heartily and continued walking.

We passed through the bustling heart of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and kept going. The farther we went, the fewer people we saw.

Where are we now?

The sheer size of the Jin Family of Taiyuan's estate spoke to its former glory. Even from a distance, it looked as large as several soccer fields combined, so it was only natural that I couldn't see everything. There were still unfamiliar places everywhere my feet took me.

Everything's run-down.

By now, the people had disappeared completely, leaving the road deserted. The occasional pavilion and other buildings whose purposes I couldn't identify were old and gloomy.

It had the kind of atmosphere where rats held sports festivals during the day and ghosts played go-stop at night.[325]

When I looked around, Jin Wikyung hurriedly began to explain.

"Given how things have been for our family, even maintaining this much has been more than we could manage. We'll need to carry out extensive renovations now, of course."

"I don't really mind."

"Really?"

"Yes."

I meant it.

I had lasted five whole years in a cramped, three-pyeong[326] goshiwon[327] studio. Rats could be caught, and as for ghosts… Well, it wasn't as if real ghosts would actually show up.

"As long as it's spacious, I don't mind."

"So, no matter what the circumstances are, you don't care as long as it's spacious?"

The premise sounded slightly ominous, but I nodded anyway. Jin Wikyung's face brightened.

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[325] Go-stop is a Korean card game commonly played with hwatu cards.

[326] One pyeong is 3.31 m^2 (35.6 ft^2); three pyeong is about 9.93 m^2 (107 ft^2).

[327] A goshiwon is a small, inexpensive rented room, often with shared facilities.

"That's a relief. I was worried you might dislike it."

"Where exactly is this place?"

"We're here. This is the building."

"Oh."

We stopped in front of a large three-story pavilion. Compared to the other buildings we had passed, it was much cleaner and had a distinctly elegant, old-fashioned charm.

I also liked the tall stone wall surrounding it.

"It's nice."

There was no reason at all to dislike a place like this.

Jin Wikyung smiled brightly, looking pleased by my reaction.

"Do you like it?"

"Yes. It's much cleaner than I expected. And it looks incredibly spacious."

"That's right. I had the training ground built large."

"A training ground!"

"I had another one built underground in case the weather was bad."

"Oh. Two training grounds!"

"If we divide them up, there shouldn't be any problem."

"Whoa. If we divide them up, that'd be perfect… Huh?"

Wait. What had he just said?

"I'm not supposed to use it alone?"

"Oh, well…"

Jin Wikyung gave an awkward smile.

"It's spacious enough for two people to use it together, isn't it? You might grow closer while you're at it."

"Who is it?"

Unease began to creep up my spine.

And bad premonitions were never wrong.

Instead of answering, Jin Wikyung strode into the pavilion.

"Mukyung! Your big brother's here!"

Oh, damn it.

"So, I'd like you two to live together until his residence is rebuilt."

After hearing the situation, Jin Mukyung readily nodded.

"Very well."

I hadn't expected him to accept so readily.

His unexpected response surprised both me and Jin Wikyung.

“Wait, are you serious?”

“Yes. But please send me one person tomorrow.”

“Of course. I was worried about you shutting yourself away in the training ground all alone anyway, so this works out well. I’ll find you a capable servant who’s quick on the uptake. Or should I bring in a cook while I’m at it?”

“A servant or a cook is unnecessary.”

“Then what?”

Jin Mukyung gave me a long, meaningful look.

“Please call a physician.”

“…”

“…”

Of course.

The scenery I had seen on the way here suddenly rose before my eyes.

An empty street with no people around. An underground training ground where not even a scream could escape. The perfect conditions for committing a crime.

He’s really made up his mind to beat me senseless.

As I shivered with a chill, Jin Wikyung stammered, “M-Mukyung. No, that’s not it, right? It’s not what I’m thinking, right?”

“It’s exactly what you’re thinking. It might be worse.”

“If it’s worse…”

“Then you’ll need to call an undertaker instead of a physician.”

I threw myself toward the exit without delay.

Whoosh! Grab!

Goddammit.

Jin Wikyung caught me by the nape and hauled me back. Jin Mukyung let out a short laugh as he watched.

“What a pathetic movement technique. Even a back-alley dog would be faster than you.”

This time I fired back without backing down.

“If something’s faster than me, is it really a dog? It’s Red Hare, isn’t it?”[328]

“Even after taking that beating, you still haven’t come to your senses.”

“Hit me! Come on, hit me!”

Of course, I had no intention of actually being hit. I had a dependable protector on my side.

“Enough!”

[328] Red Hare is the legendary swift horse associated with the historical warlord Lü Bu.

The booming shout shook the underground training ground. Unlike before, Jin Wikyung's face had hardened.

"What do you two think you're doing?"

I had never seen him like this. They said it was frightening when a kind person got angry, and Jin Wikyung now showed me exactly what that meant.

"Instead of getting along as brothers, you're trying to start a fight in front of me?"

Under his fierce glare, Jin Mukyung and I both fell silent.

"It isn't half a year or a year. It's only fifteen days. I'm asking you to live together just until the pavilion is finished. Was that such a difficult request?"

Jin Mukyung flinched. As the one responsible for demolishing the pavilion, he couldn't help feeling guilty.

"That was because that brat was being rude…"

"And that gives you the right to demolish a pavilion and beat up your little brother? You call that an excuse?"

Jin Mukyung lowered his head.

"I'm sorry."

This time, the arrow turned toward me.

"Taekyung, what about you?"

I wanted to whip out my ID card, but I held myself back.

This body was only twenty now, and Jin Mukyung was my blood brother, three years older than me.

"Answer!"

"…I'm sorry."

Jin Wikyung glared sternly at both of us.

"This is a decision I reached after careful consideration. If you dislike each other that much, say so now. I'll respect your wishes."

Jin Mukyung and I locked eyes in midair.

Our answers burst out at the same time.

"I don't want to."

"Nor do I."

"…"

After a heavy silence, Jin Wikyung finally managed to speak.

"I'm glad you two are willing to follow your big brother's wishes."

Why ask when he'd already decided on the answer?

Chapter 68

In the end, Jin Wikyung was the winner. He kept pleading with moist, puppy-dog eyes, saying, “Just half a month. No, just ten days. Can’t you two live together?” until Jin Mukyung and I threw up our hands and surrendered.

And that was how we ended up in this situation.

After Jin Wikyung left, the underground training ground fell silent, leaving just the two of us.

Jin Mukyung was the first to break the silence.

“I’ll tell you the rules.”

“Rules? What rules do two men living together need?”

“First. From now on, you will treat me with respect and use polite speech.”

“What if I refuse?”

Jin Mukyung struck the steel training dummy standing beside him.

Boom! Crack!

The steel dummy went flying and slammed into the wall. A distinct handprint had been stamped into its caved-in chest.

“What did I say the first rule was?”

I glared at Jin Mukyung. I had been through hell and back. If he thought something like this could break my spirit, he was sorely mistaken.

“You said I was to use polite speech, sir.”

…

But a mature member of society knew how to avoid unnecessary fights.

This was how adults fought. Heh.

Then why do I feel like crying?

Ah, I miss Mom.

“Good. Second. You will live as quietly as a dead mouse. If you make enough noise to wake me up or interfere with my training…”

Boom! Crack!

As the second steel dummy went flying, I nodded frantically.

“Last, the third rule. You may use the training ground freely, but if I tell you to move, you will do so without complaint. Understood?”

“Yes, yes.”

“You’re finally coming to your senses.”

Jin Mukyung nodded with satisfaction and pointed toward the exit.

“Now leave. Your room is on the third floor.”

As I hurried out of the underground training ground, his training shouts rang out behind me. Being treated like a piece of luggage made my competitive spirit flare. I turned around for a moment and made a vow.

Just you wait. I'll catch up soon.

Whoosh! Slash!

Sword Energy cleaved through the third steel dummy. As I watched its head drop limply to the floor, I revised my vow slightly.

Just you wait. I'll catch up someday.

The room was bleak. Unlike my old room, which had been decorated so lavishly that it bordered on gaudy, this one contained only a few essential pieces of furniture.

"This is a bit much, even for him."

Or should I say it was just like Jin Mukyung?

We had only met the day before, but that had been enough for me to figure out his personality. He hated anything superfluous and valued efficiency. He was also a diligent man who never neglected his training.

"…"

What the hell? The more I thought about it, the more impressive the bastard seemed.

He had a violent side, beating his own little brother like a dog for failing to use polite speech, but when I thought about it carefully, that had been self-defense.

Put yourself in the other person's shoes. Wasn't that the foundation of human relationships?

If I had a little brother like this, I would've beaten him too—and then some.

His older brothers were working their asses off to rebuild the family, while the youngest was neglecting martial arts and going crazy over alcohol and women.

Jin Wikyung only let it slide because he was a saint. Reacting with his fists like Jin Mukyung did was perfectly normal.

And he's strong, too.

Who knew? Maybe once he saw that his younger brother had turned over a new leaf, he would personally teach me martial arts.

This is an opportunity.

My eyes lit up.

Unlike Jin Wikyung and Wipeng, whom I only occasionally saw because they were so busy, Jin Mukyung spent all day holed up in the training ground.

If I received one-on-one lessons from a Peak master during the ten days we lived together, wouldn't my martial arts improve by leaps and bounds?

More than now. Much more.

Greed suddenly raised its head from deep inside me.

No, this wasn't greed. It was hunger—the hunger for everything I had never been able to possess.

Wealth and fame? I wanted them. But they were only a part of what I truly sought.

I want to become stronger.

I had thought I was strong enough, but I wasn't.

I was still nowhere near strong enough to protect the people who mattered to me. I had felt it when I faced Jopil, and again when I saw the Head Elder.

The overwhelming difference in power.

At my current level, I could barely protect my own life, let alone the people who mattered to me. I was nothing more than a frog that had only just poked its head out of a well.

I don't know how long it'll take, but I'll catch up soon enough.

It had taken me only two months to rise from Third Rate to Supreme First Rate, and from F-rank to C-rank. My current resolve was no idle boast.

The war was over, and I had plenty of time now. I intended to raise my abilities as much as possible before logging out.

Should I get myself measured again as soon as I return?

If my internal energy could support it, I could probably reach B-rank without much trouble.

I was smiling contentedly as one happy thought led to another when—

"Huh?"

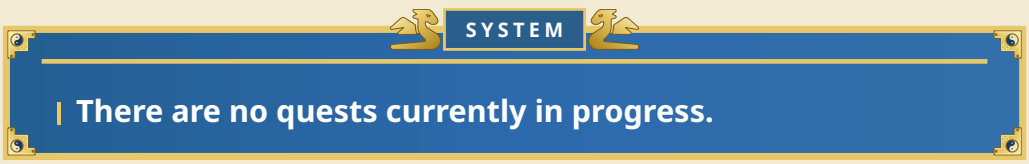
What was it?

I felt as though I had forgotten something important. As if I had overlooked something I absolutely could not afford to miss. It was the same sense of wrongness I had felt before meeting Jin Mukyung yesterday.

It did not take long to realize what it was.

"Q-Quest Window, open."

Ding.



No quests in progress?

The instant I saw the System message, my vision swam. I knew exactly what that meant.

…What about the Logout Quest?

The Logout Quest—the only way to travel between Murim and reality—was nowhere to be seen.

I was staring blankly at the System message, unable to process this unexpected situation, when—

Ding.

A new window unfolded in midair with a clear chime.

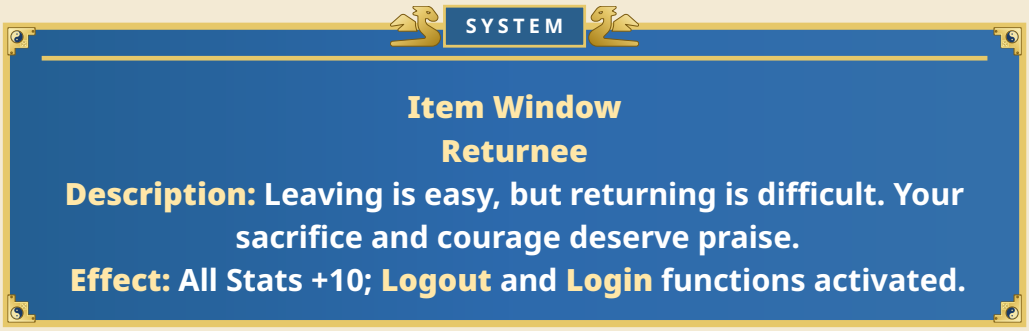
“Returnee? A new feature?”

What was this?

I hurriedly opened my Status Window, and sure enough, the word *Returnee* was sparkling brightly.

“Check Title.”

Ding.



At that moment—

Boom, boom, boom!

Fireworks exploded inside my head.

Jin Mukyung breathed.

He breathed through his nose, his mouth, and his wide-open body. The internal energy in his dantian mingled with the qi of heaven and earth flowing into him.

Whoosh.

Another name for the dantian was the qi sea—the sea of qi, where energy gathered and flowed. Jin Mukyung felt waves of qi coursing through the tiny meridians throughout his body.

And he rejoiced.

This is it.

He had first picked up a sword at the age of five. It had been a wooden sword Jin Wikyung carved with clumsy hands. He had liked the rough texture, and he had liked the sound of wind scattering every time he swung it. From that day onward, he had never taken even a single day off from training.

“He’s a genius. A true genius.”

“That boy was simply born with it. Otherwise…”

Some people had admired him. Others had envied him. Their intentions had been different, but they all said the same thing.

A genius of martial arts. A born talent.

Even while people chattered about him, Jin Mukyung remained shut away in the training ground, continuing his practice. To him, training was not painful. It was the process of becoming stronger, and it was a source of joy.

Whoosh.

What escaped with his breath was not only turbid qi. Jin Mukyung exhaled the distracting thoughts in his mind along with it.

From this point on, he had to focus solely on circulating his qi.

Can I do it today?

It was time to face the enemy he had fought every day for the past three years.

The enemy known as the Conception and Governor Vessels.[329]

He had been forced to retreat every time until now, but Jin Mukyung had not yet given up. If he won just once, he could open the Conception and Governor Vessels[330] and set foot in a new realm.

Let’s give it a try.

Just as Jin Mukyung resolutely drew up his internal energy with all his might—

“Hoooooowuuuuuuuu!”

What was that? A Heart Demon?[331]

The howl was chilling enough to raise goose bumps just by hearing it. It sounded like a demon laughing in delight. Jin Mukyung hurriedly tried to calm his internal energy when the demon shouted again.

“Strip off your voice and scream your underwear! Hoooooowuuuuuuuu!”

It wasn’t a demon.

Only one person could spout such bullshit from a pavilion that was off-limits.

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[329] The Conception and Governor Vessels are two principal channels in traditional Chinese medicine’s system of meridians.

[330] The Conception and Governor Vessels are two principal channels in traditional Chinese medicine’s system of meridians.

[331] A Heart Demon is an inner fear or obsession that can disrupt a martial artist’s concentration during cultivation.

“Jin Taekyung, you fucking—urk!”

His internal energy scattered in all directions as fury surged through him.

“What? The Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

The Sect Leader of Song Sword Sect had just been about to lie down. It was the middle of the night, and the general steward’s unexpected report jolted him wide awake.

“A-Are you sure?”

“How would I know? I’m not even a martial artist.”

The general steward was a former scholar who had retired to the countryside, and his response made the Sect Leader clutch the back of his neck.

It had been a mistake to ask someone whose head contained nothing but ink and shit.

“Then how do you know they’re from the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“The gate guards came running and said people from the Jin Family of Taiyuan were outside. And, uh, what was his name? They said some fellow called Wi… Wi-something asked if he could meet you.”

Wi-something?

The Sect Leader swallowed.

“His name wasn’t Wipeng, was it?”

“Ah, yes. Wipeng.”

The Sect Leader nearly smashed the steward’s head with his wooden pillow.

Ghost Sword Wipeng came here in person?

He was the right hand of the Lesser Family Head, Jin Wikyung, and one of the core masters of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

The thought of a Peak master who had distinguished himself in the recent war paying them a visit nearly scared the soul out of him.

“Wake everyone up! Right now!”

This was an emergency.

Even as the Sect Leader rushed outside, a thousand thoughts raced through his mind.

Is this retaliation?

Song Sword Sect was a small- to medium-sized sect in central Shanxi Province. It had fewer than fifty disciples, most of whom were only Second or Third Rate.

They had received various forms of assistance because of their close relationship with the Jin Family of Taiyuan, but when war had actually broken out, they had quietly withdrawn.

Perhaps this visit was only to be expected.

Even so, why did Ghost Sword come in person? And at this hour?

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was renowned for its fairness and integrity, so they were unlikely to do such a thing. But if they had come to annihilate Song Sword Sect, there was nothing he could do to stop them.

Even he, the strongest martial artist in the sect, might not last three moves against Wipeng.

“Sect Leader!”

The gate guards, who had been whimpering like puppies desperate to poop, brightened at the sight of their leader.

But the Sect Leader could not share their joy.

His face stiff, he politely clasped his hands[332] toward the uninvited guests.

“I am Huang, the leader of Song Sword Sect.”

At the same time, the thirty uninvited guests in bamboo hats parted to either side. Beneath the hazy moonlight, one man stepped forward.

“Good to meet you. I’m Wipeng.”

He was young, just as the Sect Leader had heard, and ruder than expected.

Song Sword Sect might have been an insignificant sect, but how could he treat its Sect Leader like that?

Still, the Sect Leader did not dare show his displeasure. The rude young man was Ghost Sword, and behind him stood the name of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

If this was the price of turning a blind eye to an ally’s crisis, then he was getting off cheap.

The Sect Leader licked his parched lips.

“I have long heard of Ghost Sword’s great reputation. If you had sent word in advance, I would have gone out to welcome you…”

“Please do not trouble yourself, Sect Leader. I only intended to deliver a letter from the Lesser Family Head and leave.”

“A letter?”

Wipeng nodded and handed him a sealed letter. The seal of the Jin Family of Taiyuan was clearly visible in the torchlight held by one of the gate guards.

“This is…”

“An invitation. The Lesser Family Head requests that you visit our family on New Year’s Day.”

The Sect Leader of Song Sword Sect had lived in Murim for many years. He immediately understood the hidden meaning.

What invitation?

[332] Clasping one fist in the other hand is a traditional greeting or salute that can convey respect.

This was both a summons and a warning.

It was a warning that if they failed to answer the summons, they would be pushed out of the future course of Shanxi Murim.

New Year's Day would be the day the victorious lord accepted new vassals.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan has drawn its sword.

After a brief silence, the Sect Leader spoke.

"I have wanted to meet the Lesser Family Head for some time… This will be an excellent opportunity."

"It is an honor that you are willing to visit."

Wipeng politely clasped his hands.[333] The abrupt change in his attitude made the Sect Leader bite his lip.

"You must be tired from your journey. Rather than standing out here, why don't you come inside and rest?"

"Thank you for the kind offer, but I think we should be leaving. There is someone we need to catch."

"The man Great Hero Wipeng is pursuing? He must be quite the villain."

"A vicious assassin. He dared to try to harm the Third Young Master."

"T-The Third Young Master? Who would dare attack the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

"Well, we assume the assassin was sent by someone hostile to our family."

"Good heavens."

"But…"

Wipeng's eyes flashed.

His sharp gaze swept through the interior of Song Sword Sect.

"Wouldn't you know it, our pursuit led us all the way to Song Sword Sect."

"T-That's impossible. Surely there has been some misunderstanding?"

The Sect Leader's heart dropped. He was about to start making hurried excuses when Wipeng smiled and waved his hand.

"Haha. Of course it must be a mistake. The whole world knows of the deep friendship between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and Song Sword Sect. How could such a thing be true?"

"…!"

"Thank you for your hospitality. I'll see you again on New Year's Day. Hyah!"

Wipeng and his subordinates disappeared into the darkness.

The Sect Leader of Song Sword Sect remained standing there for a long time.

[333] Clasping one fist in the other hand is a traditional greeting or salute that can convey respect.

Chapter 69

In the dead of night, while everyone else slept, Jin Wikyung awoke with a scream.

“Graaah!”

He flailed both arms wildly, then soon realized that he had returned to reality.

The flickering lamplight and the documents covering his desk. The familiar sight of his study.

“Phew.”

After letting out a sigh of relief, Jin Wikyung rubbed the back of his neck. It was damp with cold sweat, probably because of the nightmare.

I thought I was going to die.

He had dreamed that the earth split apart and the sky came crashing down. He had fled from a deafening roar that shook heaven and earth, running until he could barely breathe. The last thing he remembered was falling.

Maybe I’ve been pushing myself too hard.

There was more work than he could handle, but nowhere near enough people to do it. Each nerve-racking day bled into the next, and the fatigue kept piling up.

“Ugh. I need to hire more people soon. At this rate, I’ll die before my time.”

The world was vast, and there were plenty of talented people in it. And yet the Jin Family of Taiyuan still did not have a single decent strategist. That was because the family’s capabilities were lacking.

Why would anyone talented choose the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Shanxi over the great sects or renowned great families of the Central Plains, all of which would welcome them with open arms?

From their perspective, it was an obvious choice.

Until now, that is.

Everything was about to change. If the Jin Family united Shanxi Murim on New Year’s Day and continued expanding its influence…

Before long, talented people from across the land would come flocking beneath the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s banner.

Although I’ll probably die of overwork before then.

Jin Wikyung let out a deep sigh as he stared at the murderous mountain of paperwork.

That was when it happened.

Rumble.

The sound was extremely faint—so faint that only a Peak master like Jin Wikyung could have noticed it.

What was that?

He sharpened his senses. When he focused his internal energy on his ears, the sound became clearer.

Rumble. Clang.

Small, but unmistakable.

The sound of steel striking steel.

Someone was fighting. At this hour of the night, no less.

That was not the only reason Jin Wikyung's face hardened.

That direction is…

Jin Mukyung's residence lay in that direction. And as of yesterday, one more person lived there.

Surely Mukyung isn't beating up the youngest… No, of course not.

He had repeatedly urged them to get along. Surely they would not start trading blows already.

He had faith in his beloved younger brothers.

Clang. Clang!

"…"

Jin Wikyung quietly rose from his seat.

Once he fully unleashed his movement technique, Jin Wikyung reached Jin Mukyung's residence in no time.

The problem was that the closer he got, the more ominous the sounds became.

…He's probably training alone in the training ground, right?

Jin Wikyung hesitated, unsure whether to enter the pavilion. After a moment, he cautiously poked his head over the wall.

And witnessed a shocking sight.

"I told you. Rule number two. Huh?"

Boom! Crash!

Jin Mukyung swung his scabbard without pause. One person fled desperately, trying to escape him.

"Lo-Logout!"

Before Jin Taekyung could even finish his desperate cry, the scabbard flew toward him. It missed him by a hair and shattered the bluestone floor of the training ground.

Bang!

"I told you, you bastard—qi deviation! Conception and Governor Vessels!"

"Logouuuut!"

"…"

What was “Loguawk,” and why were qi deviation and the Conception and Governor Vessels suddenly coming up?

The flow of the conversation made absolutely no sense, but one thing was certain.

Something bad is going to happen if this keeps up.

At this rate, they might really have to call either a physician or an undertaker.

I’ll protect the youngest!

Jin Wikyung was about to charge in, his face set with determination, when—

“Why is your side open again? Are you that desperate to get hit?”

Whack!

“Guh!”

Jin Taekyung staggered after taking a blow to the ribs. Jin Mukyung did not miss the opening. He closed in and swung his scabbard again.

Thwack-thwack-thwack!

“Argh! Argh! Argh!”

“Don’t shrink back just because you got hit. Especially your lower body!”

Thwack!

“Grrr!”

“Oh, look at you.”

Jin Mukyung smiled disdainfully at the sight of his younger brother charging at him with his teeth clenched.

“You don’t even have the fundamentals down. First, fix that habit of throwing out your hands and feet on instinct. People learn martial arts, not beasts.”

“Shut up!”

“You have a terrible memory, too. Sleep well. When you wake up, I’ll explain the rules again.”

Whoosh! Thud.

Jin Taekyung took a direct hit to the chin, and his body crumpled. Jin Mukyung silently looked down at him lying spread-eagled on the floor, then slowly spoke.

“Please come out.”

There was no question who he was speaking to. Jin Wikyung emerged from behind the wall with an awkward expression.

“You knew I was here?”

“It would be strange if I didn’t. Every time that kid got hit, I could hear you swallowing from here like thunder.”

Jin Wikyung examined the fallen Jin Taekyung with worried eyes.

“His injuries aren’t too severe. That’s a relief.”

“It’s not like he’s going to die.”

“Mukyung!”

“Don’t worry. His bones and sinews are unbelievably sturdy.”

“Really?”

“He lasted four hours while taking a beating like that. With that kind of stamina and grit, he’ll soon… Why are you laughing?”

Jin Wikyung gazed at his younger brother’s face with a strange smile and answered cheerfully.

“It’s fascinating. Isn’t this the first time you’ve ever praised the youngest?”

Jin Mukyung stiffened.

Praise? I praised that bastard?

Impossible. His younger brother did not have a single redeeming quality. He had spent his days drowning in alcohol and chasing women, without a care for what happened to the family. And Jin Mukyung had praised him?

He forced himself to shake his head.

“…I did no such thing.”

“I see.”

“I really haven’t.”

“All right. Who said otherwise?”

“No, you’re still laughing!”

“I have never done that.”

“Hyung!”[334]

Jin Wikyung struggled to suppress the laughter bubbling up inside him. It pained him to see his beloved youngest brother hurt, but this was something Taekyung would have to experience sooner or later.

I can’t keep him under my wing forever.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

Another genius produced by the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

As he looked at his younger brother, who had grown so much in such a short time, Jin Wikyung felt both joy and unease.

No. Perhaps it was fear.

Is this even possible?

It was far too fast. Even to someone who had watched the genius Jin Mukyung from closer than anyone else, Jin Taekyung’s rate of growth was beyond comprehension.

I can’t even begin to gauge it.

As a child, Jin Wikyung had been a promising talent, but he had never been a genius. How could an ordinary man like him understand a genius, let alone teach one?

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[334] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

Just as his worries were deepening, Jin Mukyung had returned.

Jin Wikyung had known at once that this was the moment, and put the two of them together.

I was so worried because they got along so poorly…

But now that he had seen them together, he knew those worries had been unnecessary. Jin Mukyung's methods were rough, but this was clearly training, not a one-sided beating.

Training that would make the fast-growing but still inexperienced Jin Taekyung tougher and sharper.

His body would suffer, though.

It's all for your sake.

Jin Wikyung gazed down at the fallen youngest with boundless tenderness and spoke.

"I'll be going now."

But Jin Mukyung was not about to let him leave like that.

"Where do you think you're going alone? Take that kid with you. I can't live with him."

"It's ten days. Can't you endure even that much?"

"I stopped at this much today out of respect for you. If you insist, call an undertaker tomorrow."

"Are you serious?"

"Yes. So taking him with you right now would be better for him, too."

"If that is truly what you want…"

Jin Wikyung nodded and continued.

"Then do so."

"Yes, yes?"

"Do as you wish."

After tossing out that one sentence, Jin Wikyung turned and began walking away.

Imagining what expression Jin Mukyung must be wearing, he let out a quiet laugh.

This will be a good experience for you, too.

This uncomfortable arrangement was not solely for the youngest's sake.

Geniuses were always lonely. Jin Wikyung had no doubt that the two geniuses would greatly spur each other on.

"Get up, you bastard!"

Whack!

"…"

Jin Wikyung had to suppress the urge to look back the entire way home.

"You awake?"

"…"

"I know you're awake. Answer me."

"…"

"I'll give you one last chance. If you're not up by the time I count to three, this training ground will be your grave."

"…"

"One, two."

Bastard. He counts ridiculously fast.

I quietly got up and stretched.

"Whew, I slept well."

When I casually turned my head, I found Jin Mukyung glaring at me.

The sight of his face brought yesterday's memories flooding back.

A man without blood or tears. A bastard who deserved to be beaten to death.

I addressed him in an innocent voice.

"Oh? Hyung-nim.[335] When did you get here?"

"…Just now."

Seeing Jin Mukyung smack his lips with disappointment, I decided that switching to formal speech had been a stroke of genius. If he found even one thing to nitpick, he was the type to beat me like a dog.

Fuck… Being weak is a sin. A sin.

I had my pride, too. But in an unarmed fight, I could not beat Jin Mukyung even if I died and came back to life.

While that bastard had been learning systematic fist and kicking techniques, I had been watching UFC matches. He was not someone I could overcome through sheer stubbornness.

That was why I had chosen Logout as my last resort.

Of course, it had failed spectacularly.

You can't Logout during combat? What kind of bullshit rule is that?

They could have told me beforehand. I had charged in without knowing and nearly gotten logged out of life.

I cast a sidelong glance at Jin Mukyung.

"Hey."

"Yes?"

[335] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

“Me?”

At his icy tone, I made my eyes as bright and innocent as possible.

Now I even had to watch how I looked at him if I wanted one less beating.

“You… Hah. Watch yourself.”

“Yes, Hyung-nim.”[336]

Jin Mukyung looked displeased by my sudden politeness. But he could hardly hit me just for having good manners.

“About yesterday…”

I quickly bowed my head.

“It was my fault. I made so much noise while you were training. I deserved to get hit.”

“No, hey.”

“Oh, no. Your hand must hurt from hitting me yesterday. Would you like me to blow on it?”

“You’re completely insane.”

Jin Mukyung looked as though he was debating whether to hit me, but eventually gave up and lowered his fist.

“Enough. Follow me.”

“…Where?”

“The training ground.”

I took back what I had just thought. He planned to beat me in the training ground.

He could not exactly turn my room into a wasteland again.

Jin Mukyung clicked his tongue when he saw my expression stiffen.

“It’s not that. Follow me. Training starts today.”

“Training?”

“Yes. I’m going to tear apart those horrible martial arts of yours and rebuild them from the ground up.”

The man who had beaten me senseless every time he saw me was suddenly offering to help me train? And he was even carving out time from his own schedule?

I’d sooner believe the Demon King Asmodeus had repented.

Perhaps he noticed the suspicion in my eyes, because Jin Mukyung let out a deep sigh.

“Hyung[337] came by yesterday.”

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[336] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

[337] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

"Ah."

His personality might have been foul, but he had a clear sense of rank and propriety. If Jin Wikyung had personally asked him, the current situation made sense.

"There are several empty buildings. Why do you think he sent you to me? Damn it. I should have refused from the beginning."

...I suppose he really did not want to teach me.

But I desperately needed his help. If nothing else, there had to be some use for learning even one decent fist-and-kicking technique from him.

"Please teach me."

Jin Mukyung shook his head.

"Think before you speak. Meeting my standards will be difficult. If you're going to give up as soon as things become hard, quit now."

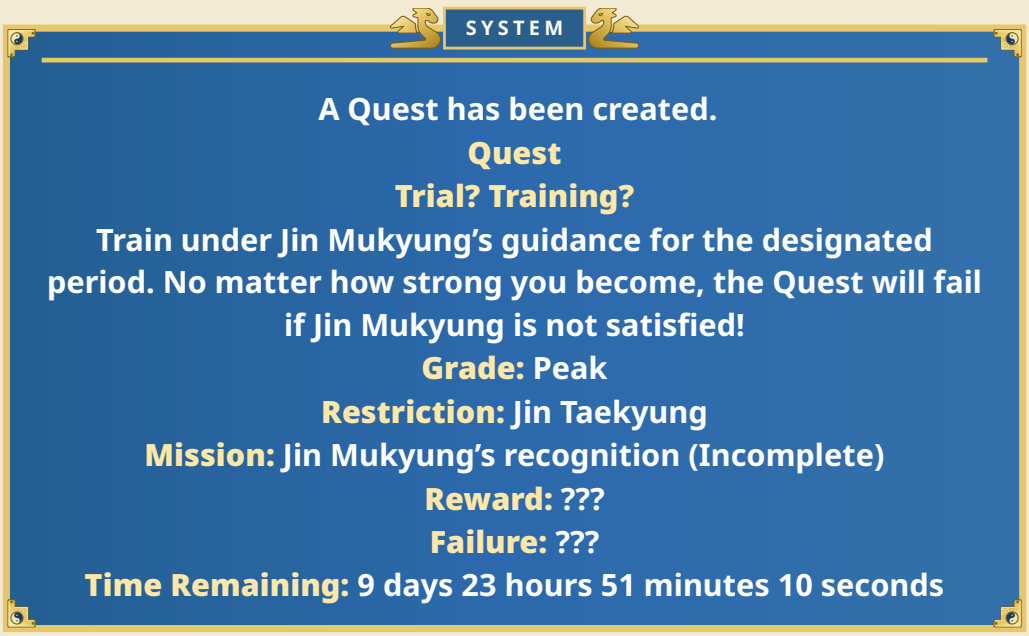
If I had given up every time things became difficult, I would never have made it this far.

"I want to become stronger."

Perhaps he sensed the sincerity in my voice. After staring at me for a long time, he finally opened his mouth.

"Come out to the training ground."

Ding.



Jin Mukyung's recognition.

It was an abstract mission, but I was confident enough. If I combined the System's cheat-like advantages with my own effort, I could grow so quickly that Jin Mukyung's eyes would pop out.

I can do this.

That was when I was steeling my resolve.

“Oh, right. You use a spear, don’t you?”

“Ah, yes.”

“Bring that with you, too.”

Jin Mukyung was a swordsman, so I had naturally assumed he would focus on teaching me fist techniques. Confused, I cautiously asked,

“Why the spear all of a sudden…?”

“Train as if it were real combat. Haven’t you heard that saying?”

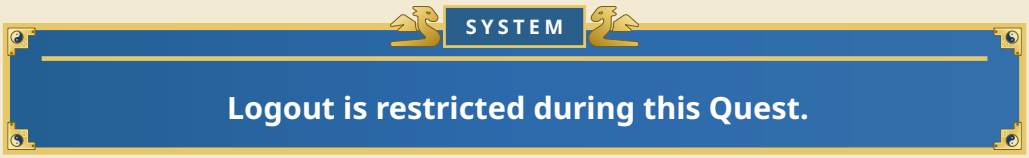
Jin Mukyung smiled brightly and added:

“I even got Hyung’s[338] permission. He said he doesn’t mind if we have to call an undertaker.”

I stared blankly at his back as he walked away with light, cheerful steps. At last, I managed to open my mouth.

“…Logout.”

Beep.



What the fuck.

[338] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

Chapter 70

Outside, dawn was dim. The winter air was cold as ice, and frost crumbled underfoot with every step across the training ground.

Jin Mukyung, who had already been warming up, grinned at me.

“Well? Are you mentally prepared?”

Of course not. But I hid my churning stomach and nodded.

Someone once said that if you couldn’t avoid something, you should enjoy it. Thinking of this as just another step toward becoming stronger made me feel a little more at ease…

Shing.

“Then let’s see that impressive skill of yours.”

Is this bastard Korean? Why is he so impatient?

I had no time to avoid him. Jin Mukyung rushed toward me in an instant, and I hurriedly swung my spear shaft at him.

Clang! Kaga-gang!

Jin Mukyung’s breath drifted between us over our locked weapons.

“Your stance isn’t bad.”

It had to be. I had survived seven years in a Gate where my life had been on the line, using nothing but a spear. The experience I’d built up with the spear was on a completely different level from my fists and kicks.

I glared into his eyes and answered.

“This time, it won’t be easy.”

One word at a time. Clearly and distinctly.

“You…”

Had he sensed my unusual aura? Jin Mukyung’s eyes trembled.

“Can’t you keep your damn eyes open?”

“Oh.”

Swoosh. Thud!

Jin Taekyung collapsed.

It was hardly surprising. This was already his fifth knockout.

The real surprise lay elsewhere.

I can’t believe he lasted two hundred exchanges against me.

Five spars over two shichen—roughly four hours.

Anyone would have been exhausted. But Jin Taekyung was different. He kept springing back up like a roly-poly toy, growing stronger each time. By the final spar, even Jin Mukyung had been forced to take him seriously.

What the hell is this guy?

Unarmed, his movements had been as clumsy as those of an eighty-year-old man. But the moment he picked up a spear, everything changed.

The coward who had fawned over Jin Mukyung to avoid getting hit had vanished. In his place stood a seasoned spearman.

He was like a wandering martial artist. Someone who had survived countless brushes with death.

His movements were so simple they seemed crude, while his irregular attacks and evasions relied entirely on instinct. A wandering martial artist's fighting style followed no fixed pattern.

That was exactly what Jin Taekyung looked like to Jin Mukyung.

Which only made the question more baffling.

How?

Even among the heirs of prestigious families who picked up a sword as soon as they learned to walk, countless people only hovered around the threshold of First Rate. Yet this man had stood before the wall of the Peak realm in just three years.

And he did it while giving off not the scent of a courtesan's powder, but the strong scent of a seasoned wandering martial artist. The more Jin Mukyung thought about it, the more absurd it seemed.

Was something like this even possible?

Technically, yes.

Having a Supreme Peak master cleanse his tendons and marrow. Improving his constitution with elixirs. Then swinging a spear until he shit blood while building real combat experience.

Every single day for three years!

"…That's ridiculous."

Jin Mukyung muttered hollowly and scratched his head.

Then only one answer remained.

A genius.

That one word resolved every question with perfect clarity.

Why?

Because he was a genius. Someone blessed by heaven, just as the word implied. Someone born with talent.

Geniuses were ahead in every way. They started from a completely different place.

"Zzz… Hoo…"

"…"

But of all people, this guy was a genius?

That was impossible. It couldn't be allowed!

Anger suddenly surged within Jin Mukyung, and he kicked his younger brother in the rear.

"Prrrblblbl."

Jin Taekyung rolled away several times before shuddering all over.

"W-Wolhwa noona[339]. Not there."

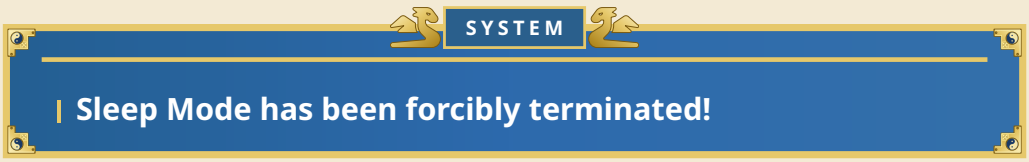
"…!"

"If you suddenly do this… Ah. Aah!"

Crack.

The last thread of Jin Mukyung's patience snapped.

Beep!



So it can be forcibly terminated?

My joy at discovering a new function lasted only a moment. Why had Sleep Mode been forcibly terminated?

Because someone had woken me up, obviously.

"On the sacred training ground, you say what? 'Not there'? 'Not there'?"

Whack! Whack! Whack!

Curled up like a shrimp, I pleaded in a dying voice.

"Please, spare me…"

"No!"

Thwack-thwack-thwack!

I had no idea how many times he hit me. I lost consciousness twice in the middle of it.

My last memory was of collapsing while using the last of my strength to leave a dying message on the training ground. When I opened my eyes, it was already night.

What did I even do for it to be night already?

I felt like a time traveler. Ever since I had met Jin Mukyung, entire days had been flying by.

[339] *Noona* is a Korean term a younger man uses to address an older sister or a familiar older woman.

Pain swept through my body as I muttered, “Jin Mukyung really is strong.”

Excluding Jin Mukyung, I had faced two Peak masters so far.

The Head Elder and Jopil.

The Head Elder doesn’t count.

In his case, I had to admit that luck had been on my side. If not for the sacrifices of the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s martial artists and Lee Cheonbaek’s surprise attack, he was a master I could never have defeated in a million years.

Then how does Jopil compare to Jin Mukyung?

I did not have to think for long.

I had fought both of them, so the choice was easy.

Jin Mukyung is stronger.

Jopil was unquestionably a monster. Even now, I got goose bumps whenever I remembered the savage heat pouring from his Flame Divine Palm.

But how should I put it? He was strong like a Peak master, and he used the deadly Flame Divine Palm, but that was all.

More precisely, it was a difference in how they used their martial arts.

Jin Mukyung was different from Jopil. Even during our spar, he had used more than ten different martial arts to completely shut down my attacks.

To a martial artist, martial arts were another weapon. Jin Mukyung knew how to draw out the right weapon at exactly the right moment.

Compared to him, what did I have?

Setting aside the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique, which I had possessed from the beginning, the only martial arts I had learned in Murim were the Jin Family’s Spear Technique and the Jin Family’s Manoeuvre Technique.

Of course, both were unquestionably First Rate martial arts.

But put another way, they were only useful at the First Rate level.

The limitations of my martial arts. There was no way Jin Wikyung had failed to notice what I had felt.

That must be why he put me with Jin Mukyung. Ugh.

The pain made my brow furrow on its own. I had barely raised my upper body, yet every joint throbbed and my skin stung.

Apparently, even the rest provided by Sleep Mode had its limits.

Well, I did get beaten half to death.

To complete the Quest by earning Jin Mukyung’s recognition, I would have to endure days like today—or even worse ones.

Maybe I would simply get beaten senseless and fail the Quest anyway.

It really is one mountain after another.

And that made me happy.

As an F-rank Hunter, I had not even been given the right to climb a mountain. But everything had changed.

There was a mountain I had to climb, and I had been given the right to climb it.

Faster than anyone else!

This isn't the time for this.

Forgetting the pain, I rose. I could not bear to waste another minute or second.

Jin Mukyung was in the underground training ground.

I descended the stairs as quietly as possible and spotted him below.

"Hah!"

With a short shout, his sword moved.

Whoosh! Shh-shh-shhk!

The wind split along the blade.

Jin Mukyung moved without hesitation, thrusting and slashing through empty space at the speed of a ray of light.

About fifteen minutes passed before he lowered his sword and released a long breath.

"Hoo."

He wiped away his sweat with his sleeve, then turned toward me.

It seemed he had noticed my presence some time ago.

"Tell me."

The words came out of nowhere.

Caught off guard, I asked, "Tell you what?"

"About the martial art I just performed."

"Uh, well, first of all, it was really fast…"

"For the record, if you spout pointless bullshit like 'It was fast' or 'It was strong,' I'll kill you."

He's a mind reader.

I racked my brain for an answer that would keep me alive.

What had Jin Mukyung's martial art been like?

As I thought about it carefully, a vague impression began to surface.

"Rough?"

Jin Mukyung's eyebrow twitched.

Was that the right answer?

"Did you just speak informally to me?"

"…It seemed rough."

"Even a little kid could say that. Be more specific."

The image in my head gradually became clearer.

I remembered the blade pouring down upon an imaginary enemy and the movements that accompanied it. Fast and unrestrained. And the aura pressing down from every direction.

It was like…

“A waterfall?”

“…”

“Huh?”

What? Was that the right answer?

After a long silence, Jin Mukyung abruptly swung his scabbard.

Smack!

“Ow! Why did you hit me?”

“Just because.”

He stared at me with a strange look in his eyes.

“How did someone like you ever come out?”

Was that an insult or a compliment?

I had no idea what he truly meant, but I had to hear the answer to his question if only because I felt wronged. Rubbing my throbbing forehead, I asked:

“So, was that the correct answer?”

“There are thousands of martial arts manuals in Heaven’s Gate Temple. They were arrangements left behind by the departed Seniors who hoped to cultivate the younger generation of the orthodox Murim.”

“And?”

“The Falling Flow Sword you just saw is one of them. I found it buried deep in the archives.”

Falling flow. In other words, falling water.

A waterfall.

I had simply blurted out the first thing that came to mind, but it had actually been the right answer.

“Oh, ooh.”

Am I really a genius?

If I could recognize martial arts like this after only two months of learning them, I was afraid of how strong I might become in the future. Even I found myself frightening.

“Surely you’re not having the embarrassing thought that you’re a genius or something after managing only that much?”

“…”

He really is a mind reader.

Still, I seemed to have at least a little talent.

Unable to let go of the thought, I cautiously asked, “Can everyone normally do this much?”

Jin Mukyung flinched.

“O-Of course. Anyone with eyes should be able to guess this much.”

“Come on.”

“‘Come on’? Want me to pluck out one of your eyes?”

“…That might be a bit much.”

Why is this bastard being especially stone-faced today? Did something unpleasant happen?

Even after I backed down, Jin Mukyung could not contain his anger. He kept huffing angrily.

“It’s basic. Basic. Everyone can do it.”

“I said I get it. Why do you keep getting angry? You’re scaring me.”

“Are you rebelling against me? Is it because you’re going through the storm-and-stress stage of adolescence? Do you want to get beaten with the Twelve Gale Fists?”

I did not know what the Twelve Gale Fists were, but getting hit by them sounded painful.

I shook my head fiercely, but Jin Mukyung’s anger showed no sign of fading.

“Do you know martial arts? Huh?”

“N-No, sir.”

“How long have you been learning martial arts?”

The answer slipped out reflexively.

“Two months. Two months.”

“Right, a bastard who’s only been at it for two months… What? Two months?”

Jin Mukyung glared at me with bloodshot eyes.

“Not three years, but two months?”

This was an emergency.

The social instincts I had gained through seven years of working life shone at that moment. I hurriedly opened my mouth, making sure to emphasize one particular part.

“Three years! Plus two months!”

Jin Mukyung’s fist had been trembling as though he had suffered a stroke, but it steadied again. For some reason, even his voice seemed slightly gentler.

“You little bastard. You startled me.”

You startled me even more, you son of a bitch.

Does he have anger-management issues?

If he asked Jin Wikyung, my lie would be exposed immediately. But at least I would avoid the misfortune of experiencing the Twelve Gale Fists right now.

In any case, Jin Mukyung's anger subsided in the meantime.

"I'll say this only once. Listen carefully."

"I'll engrave it on my heart."

I bowed deeply, and he declared in a domineering tone, "I teach. You obey."

"…"

Is this a dog-training school or what?

"There will be no objections. Why? Because I'm stronger than you."

It was true, so I had no desire to argue.

Money, power, and force. Their forms might differ, but the world always revolved around the strong.

I wanted to stand at its center.

"What will you do?"

My answer had been decided a long time ago.

Chapter 71

The Jin Family's Spear Technique consisted of seven forms. The last of them, Sky-Piercing Strike, smashed into the steel dummy.

Boom!

With a deafening crash, the dummy's chest caved in and it slammed into the wall. As I drew back my spear, Jin Mukyung's voice reached my ears.

"The Jin Family's Spear Technique is passable."

"Uh, yes."

"The Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique is about the same."

Wait. Had I ever told him what martial arts I had learned?

As I searched my memory, Jin Mukyung let out a quiet laugh.

"Do you know why I entered Heaven's Gate Temple?"

"Um. Because you couldn't stand the sight of me?"

"…That's not entirely wrong."

He muttered under his breath and nodded, then suddenly caught himself.

"Ahem. There was a more important reason than that."

"What was it?"

"There were no martial arts left for me to learn in our family."

"What?"

"I needed something new. As luck would have it, Heaven's Gate Temple offered me admission, and I had no reason to refuse."

"Then what about the Jin Family's Spear Technique?"

"I just told you. There was nothing left for me to learn."

"No, but you're a swordsman."

"So?"

"Huh?"

"Don't you eat side dishes with your rice?"

"That's different."

"It's the same to me."

It's different to me.

I've learned to use several different weapons, too, but…

My situation was completely different from Jin Mukyung's. That had not been martial arts. It had been a desperate struggle to survive my battles with monsters.

Once I became accustomed to the spear, I had not had the time to look elsewhere.

Focusing on just one thing was already difficult enough.

"You look like you don't understand. It'll be faster if I show you."

Shing.

Jin Mukyung drew his sword and stood before the steel dummy.

He flexed his hands for a moment to warm up, then murmured, “Let’s try it like this.”

His legs crossed in a blur. A flash followed, slamming into the steel dummy’s chest.

Swoooosh! Boom!

I was speechless. The form was slightly different, but the movements were familiar. There was no way I could fail to recognize them.

“This is…”

“Sky-Piercing Strike. The final form of the Jin Family’s Spear Technique. Though in this case, I suppose I should call it the Jin Sword Technique.”

For a moment, I could not speak. Then I remembered something I had briefly forgotten.

Jin Mukyung was a genius. An ordinary person might struggle just to finish a bowl of plain rice, but Jin Mukyung could digest an eight-dish spread without trouble.

Genius. Genius. I’d only ever heard the word before.

By adding and removing just a few simple movements, he had transformed the Jin Family’s Spear Technique into a sword technique.

A genius of martial arts. The rumors had not been exaggerated in the slightest.

This bastard… He’s the real deal.

The System helped its user grow quickly. It did not turn them into a genius. But Jin Mukyung had been born one.

The move he had just shown me was probably no more than the tip of the iceberg. The thought sent a chill down my spine.

“Are you listening to me?”

His cold voice snapped me back to my senses.

“Ah, yes.”

“Your hyung[340] went to the trouble of giving you a demonstration, and you dare let your mind wander?”

Flick!

“Gah.”

My vision flashed. Jin Mukyung watched me suffer with satisfaction before speaking again.

“I’ll explain it one more time, so concentrate. Understand?”

“Gnh. Yes, sir.”

“Anyway, martial arts are…”

“…”

“Uh, martial arts are… Ah, damn it.”

[340] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male he is close to.

Jin Mukyung's face flushed red as he shouted.

"You made me forget!"

Whack!

You fucking bastard…

In the end, Jin Mukyung chose conversation as his method.

A physical conversation.

"You don't understand when things are explained in words. It'll be faster for you to experience them with your body."

"W-Wait a moment."

"There's no 'wait a moment' in real combat. Would you say that to someone who came to kill you? 'I'm nervous, so I need to take a piss first.' Do you think he'd tell you to go take a shit while you're at it?"

"We're sparring right now!"

"Huh? Informal speech again. You're dead."

Jin Mukyung tightened his grip on his wooden sword and charged at me like a leopard.

I threw myself aside without waiting to see what happened.

Boom!

Leaving the bone-rattling crash behind me, I snatched a wooden practice spear from the rack. An ominous voice followed close behind.

"From now on, I'll teach you a lesson."

Swoooosh!

The sound of air tearing was anything but ordinary. I turned and swung my spear at the same time, but I was already too late. The faintly upturned corner of Jin Mukyung's mouth was right in front of me.

"First."

Thud!

His fist shot up from below and struck my lower jaw. My feet left the ground against my will.

Through my wavering vision, Jin Mukyung's voice continued.

"When fighting someone more skilled than yourself, be cautious."

The next moment, Jin Mukyung's palm struck my chest. With a bang like a bursting balloon, I flew backward and slid all the way to the wall.

"Cough."

My organs did not spill out along with a mouthful of blood. When I lifted my head, I saw Jin Mukyung slowly walking toward me.

"You scared little brat. Did you really think your hyung[341] would use internal energy against his younger brother?"

I answered gruffly.

"Then throw away the wooden sword."

"I can't. It feels better with this."

That was the confidence of the strong. Even so, he was not careless enough to discard his weapon.

This is going to be difficult.

Fortunately, Jin Mukyung was easy to provoke.

Especially when it came to me.

"Did you chicken out?"

"What?"

The smile vanished from Jin Mukyung's face. I was afraid of what he might do to me later, but that was a problem for later. Right now, I wanted to beat the bastard in front of me somehow.

"I asked if you chickened out."

"I don't really know what that means… but it's really pissing me off."

The instant he finished speaking, Jin Mukyung rushed at me. His movements were noticeably rougher than before. I knocked aside the wooden sword descending toward my shoulder with the shaft of my spear.

Krrrk.

Did they coat this wooden sword with glue?

I needed to open up some distance, but the sword would not come away. It coiled around my spear shaft like a snake and thrust toward me.

"What the hell is this?"

"What else? The Jin Family's Spear Technique. No, the Jin Sword Technique."

The Jin Sword Technique? This?

"It's completely different from what you showed me earlier!"

"Ah. I mixed in a few other sword techniques."

"That's cheating!"

"Second. Never forget that while you were drinking yourself stupid with women, I was training in blood and sweat."

At the same time, the wooden sword slammed into my side.

Thud!

Never mind the pain; a deep fury surged through me.

What? Drinking with women?

[341] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male he is close to.

While everyone else was holding hands with their girlfriends and going on Christmas dates, I was having a group date with monsters in a Gate, you fucking bastard!

Whack-whack-whack!

The wooden sword pounded my thigh and forearm in quick succession, but I felt nothing. My anger had overwhelmed the pain.

I gritted my teeth and sent my spear flying in every direction.

Sshh-shh-shhk! Clang!

Under the sharp assault, Jin Mukyung began to give ground little by little. Combat was all about momentum. My instincts, honed through countless real battles, whispered to me.

Now!

I brought my spear down with all my strength toward the crown of his head.

Boom!

The crash was loud enough to leave my ears ringing. But the attack had not landed properly.

Jin Mukyung raised his sword and blocked the spear with ease. He snorted.

“Too obvious.”

“Yeah. If it’s too obvious, it’s no fun.”

With a triumphant grin, I drove my fist toward his abdomen.

It’s a feint, you bastard!

The provocation and the attack before it had all been for this moment.

At this distance, martial arts did not matter. One punch to the solar plexus, and not even a Peak master’s grandfather would stand a chance.

It’s over.

My fist, carrying all the resentment I had built up, slammed into Jin Mukyung’s solar plexus.

Clang!

…Clang?

What the hell was that?

My confusion lasted only a moment before a scream burst out.

From my mouth.

“Argh! My hand!”

It hurt! And it hurt like hell!

Through my pain-blurred vision, I saw Jin Mukyung bashfully lift his shirt. A bulging leather vest appeared beneath his martial arts uniform.

What is that?

A bulletproof vest? No. But it looked like it could stop bullets. Every pocket in the leather vest had been crammed full of iron ingots.

"Third…"

Jin Mukyung pulled a dented iron ingot from a pocket near his solar plexus. My fistprint was clearly visible.

"Fight only after discerning your opponent's intentions."

"Why the hell are you wearing that?"

"Fourth. Never neglect physical conditioning, even in everyday life."

"Damn it!"

Martial arts? Forms? To hell with all that. I cast off the awkward guise of a martial artist and returned to being a Hunter with seven years of experience.

My hand was already injured, so properly using the Jin Family's Spear Technique would be difficult. Besides, Jin Mukyung knew every martial art I had learned.

I'll show you what a real fight looks like.

With all my strength, I kicked Jin Mukyung in the shin as he grinned triumphantly. It was a decisive technique known as a soccer kick, or simply a shin-kick.

I had never seen anyone stay fine after taking one of these.

Clang!

Add one more to the list.

"You fucking—"

"You idiot."

Jin Mukyung looked down at me as I collapsed, clutching my foot. His expression seemed to say that I was the most pathetic person alive.

"Fifth… Never mind. I'm getting tired of talking."

He pulled a flat metal plate from beneath his pant leg and strode toward me. I tried to limp to my feet, but he kicked my ankle out from under me and sent me back down.

Damn it.

It was over.

If I used Inventory, I might have a chance to turn things around, but I did not want to do something so blatantly suspicious right in front of him. I lowered my head with a sigh.

"Let's stop."

"You want to stop?"

I lifted my head at his hard voice. Jin Mukyung's face had gone cold.

"After only this much?"

The man who had been grinning as he gleefully beat me only moments ago was nowhere to be seen.

His emotionless gaze made my skin prickle. My Adam's apple bobbed.

Gulp.

Almost simultaneously with the sound of me swallowing, the wooden sword slammed into my right shoulder.

My arm buckled with a thud, throwing me off balance.

“Guh. What the hell are you doing…?”

Jin Mukyung ignored me and swung the wooden sword again. The Jin Mukyung standing before me now seemed unable to hear the voice of the defeated.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

He struck my left arm, then both legs. Only then did his hand stop.

“You just had all four limbs cut off. By a vicious Peak master of the dark path[342] who is several times stronger than you.”

“…”

“If he were even nastier, he’d have other methods.”

Tap-tap-tap.

The instant Jin Mukyung’s hand blurred, my entire body went rigid and my tongue curled back. The System immediately alerted me to the abnormal conditions.

Beep!

SYSTEM

The Paralysis Acupoint has been subdued. You will be paralyzed for two hours!

The Mute Acupoint has been subdued. You will be unable to make a sound for two hours!

I could not move so much as a hair or make a single sound.

A breathing corpse. In my current state, even a child could kill me.

Jin Mukyung. You insane bastard!

The curses could only circle inside my head, unable to escape my lips. All I could do was glare at him. Jin Mukyung calmly met my furious gaze.

“Tendon-Splitting and Bone-Twisting is a cruel technique. Within an hour at most, your qi and blood will twist and every bone in your body will be crushed. Even if you miraculously survive, you’ll either go insane or spend the rest of your life crippled.”

“…”

“Do you think you could endure that pain? You’d probably forget who you are within fifteen minutes.”

My stomach churned. Not because of his explanation of Tendon-Splitting and Bone-Twisting.

[342] The *dark path* refers to underworld martial groups, as opposed to those considered orthodox.

It was Jin Mukyung's eyes. There was no emotion in them. Those black eyes were unfamiliar and frightening.

Could Jin Mukyung really be about to kill me?

No. That was impossible. I was Jin Taekyung. A direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and Jin Mukyung's only younger brother.

But what he did next went far beyond anything I had expected.

"Don't worry. I'll send you off without pain."

Something cold touched my throat as he spoke in a low voice. It was the metal plate Jin Mukyung had pulled out earlier. Its thin, sharp edge slowly dug into my flesh.

I'm going to die? Like this?

I had survived dozens of brushes with death. In Gates, and in Murim. I had struggled all this time to survive somehow…

And now I was about to die without even being able to blink.

To that bastard who was supposed to be my biological older brother, even though we did not share a single drop of blood!

What the fuck kind of situation is this?

My body rigid, I could only stare at the ceiling as the voice of the Reaper reached my ears.

"Die."

Slice.

The strength drained from my entire body. I felt hot blood trickling down my neck.

Jin Taekyung. Aged twenty-seven. Gone to sleep in Murim.

I slowly closed my eyes.

"…"

No, wait. Something was wrong.

My acupoints were sealed, but I just closed my eyes?

At that moment—

Ding.

SYSTEM

The Paralysis Acupoint has been released. The paralysis has ended!

The Mute Acupoint has been released. You can speak freely!

"Get up."

"…"

At Jin Mukyung's voice, I slowly opened my eyes. All five of my senses were sharp and clear, proving that I was alive.

How?

I hurriedly felt the back of my neck. The cut stung, and blood came away on my fingers, but there were only a few drops of it. Everything else had been an illusion brought on by the fear and tension of death.

"Remember."

His cold voice continued—the same voice that had pronounced my death only seconds earlier.

"You died once today."

Chapter 72

"You died once today."

His cold voice continued.

"Your limbs were cut off, you were subjected to Tendon-Splitting and Bone-Twisting, and your throat was cut. The degree and form of the pain may have been different, but you died. Without a doubt."

Once the relief of being alive faded, anger took its place.

I rose on trembling legs, swallowed the blood pooled in my mouth, and glared at Jin Mukyung.

This fucking lunatic.

I wanted to drive my fist into that smug face right away, but I held myself back. Not because I was weaker than Jin Mukyung. Because I knew he was right.

"…So? What are you trying to say?"

His answer came immediately, as if he had been waiting for me to ask.

"That your days are numbered."

"What?"

"You're only half-finished. Neither a martial artist nor a wandering martial artist. Just an incomplete mess. A sloppy bastard like you is begging to die the moment he ventures into the Murim."

Half-finished.

That might have been the most accurate description of my current state. I was both a Hunter and a martial artist.

"Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi? Supreme First Rate master? Even a passing dog would laugh. You're nothing but a brawler. You're sloppy for a martial artist, and you don't even fight as pragmatically as a wandering martial artist. Don't mistake surviving through good luck for skill."

I barely managed to open my mouth.

"Then what about Jopil? According to you, was that just luck too?"

"Jopil, One Question, One Kill? He was obviously an idiot who let his guard down in front of an enemy. You just happened to have one last move that could turn the tables."

"…!"

"What? Do you think I guessed too accurately despite not seeing it myself?"

Jin Mukyung clicked his tongue.

"Even a deaf old man knows that the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan is a wastrel. Did Jopil not know? The moment he let his guard down, he was finished too."

What is this bastard, a stalker?

I felt like Sun Wukong trapped in the Buddha's palm.[343] His guess was that accurate.

"Let me make this clear."

Jin Mukyung fixed me with a somber gaze.

"That luck of yours ends here."

"…"

"The Murim is crawling with all kinds of monsters. And they don't let their guard down like Jopil did. You're no longer the Jin Family's wastrel of a Third Young Master. You're the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

Every word stabbed straight into my vitals. Everything Jin Mukyung said was true, and it was time for me to face reality.

"Damn it."

He was right. I was half-finished.

Thanks to the greatest stroke of luck in my life—the System—I had somehow survived this long. But it seemed that luck had taken me exactly this far.

But… I really am lucky.

Not only had I discovered the problem early, but an excellent problem-solver was standing right in front of me to help solve it.

"Help me."

Jin Mukyung.

A fully realized Peak martial artist and a genius of martial arts.

And—

"…Hyung."[344]

My older brother.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Time Limit: 9 days 20 hours 23 minutes

Murim people were a proud lot. Even a Third Rate wandering martial artist who wore a rusty sword at his waist and drank cheap baijiu[345] was like that, so the arrogance of scions from prestigious sects reached the heavens.

[343] Sun Wukong, the Monkey King of *Journey to the West*, could not escape the Buddha's palm despite his extraordinary powers.

[344] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[345] *Baijiu* is a Chinese distilled liquor.

“Help me, hyung.”[346]

In that sense, this guy had become a decent human being. Three years ago, he would have run to his eldest brother with tears in his eyes… but he had grown. Far more than expected.

He’s a strange one.

Neither his personality nor his martial arts were easy to pin down. That was both a strength and a weakness. But one thing was certain: none of it would work against a *true master*.

But his talent is real.

Over the past three years at Heaven’s Gate Temple, Jin Mukyung had encountered countless prodigies, but none could match Jin Taekyung’s rate of growth.

And he has strengths they don’t.

He had the eye to grasp martial arts at a glance, excellent instincts in real combat, and an ear for other people’s advice.

Though for now, he’s still a half-finished mess with everything jumbled together.

Given time, his weaknesses would be filled in and his excesses smoothed out. When that happened, Jin Taekyung’s martial arts would be complete.

Like taiji[347] achieving harmony.

Taiji? Is that a little too grandiose?

This was starting to become burdensome.

But he could not contain his curiosity. How would that bastard grow? How far would he climb?

I’m going to be busy.

He had to leave and return to Heaven’s Gate Temple within fifteen days at the latest. Jin Mukyung finally opened his mouth.

“What are you doing? Pick up your spear.”

“Hyung!”[348]

Seeing Jin Taekyung’s face light up, Jin Mukyung suddenly had a thought.

When did this bastard start speaking informally to me?

That was the moment the intensity of the training rose another level.

Bang.

Jin Wikyung stamped his seal on the final document, his eyes heavily bloodshot.

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[346] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[347] *Taiji* is a Chinese philosophical concept in which complementary forces form a balanced whole.

[348] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

He had been freed from nearly twenty hours of backbreaking labor, but he was not happy at all. New work would be piled up by tomorrow morning anyway.

Are these things breeding behind my back?

At least the end was finally coming into sight. That was some consolation.

After completing his final review, Jin Wikyung rang a small bell. Before its clear sound had even faded, two sturdily built servants appeared.

“Did you call, Lesser Family Head?”

“Take these away.”

“Yes, sir.”

The servants skillfully stacked the documents onto a cart. Just as they were about to leave, Jin Wikyung spoke.

“Ah. You stay.”

The servant he had singled out blinked in surprise.

“Me, sir?”

“That’s right. You.”

Once the two of them were alone, Jin Wikyung began speaking in a solemn voice.

“So, how have you been finding the work lately?”

“Very well, sir. It’s all thanks to your kindness, Lesser Family Head.”

“Nothing causing you any inconvenience?”

“Oh, goodness. Of course not.”

The servant, Childeuk, did nothing but nod repeatedly. He was illiterate and could not even get through the Thousand Character Classic,[349] but he still had ears to hear and eyes to see.

After its victory in the recent war, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had risen to become the foremost family in Shanxi. Its Lesser Family Head, Jin Wikyung, had begun to be called the Junzi Sword[350] for his swift recovery efforts and fair handling of the aftermath.

Why would such a great man want me?

His heart pounded with nerves. Had he made some mistake? Or had Jin Wikyung perhaps noticed his talent for martial arts?

The former would be disastrous. The latter would be a chance to turn his life around.

My bones and muscles are sturdy, at least. I never even had a stomachache as a child.

He could already see himself wearing a sword at his waist and letting his hero’s headband flutter in the wind.

But when Jin Wikyung saw Childeuk’s eyes glaze over, he flinched.

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[349] The *Thousand Character Classic* is a classical Chinese text used to teach literacy.

[350] *Junzi* is a Confucian ideal referring to a morally upright and cultivated gentleman.

What's with this guy?

Childeuk's eyes were filled with desperate longing, as if he were willing to offer his soul to obtain whatever he wanted.

It was not the sort of look one man should give another.

Don't tell me…?

Male love, something he had only heard about…

No. That could not be it. He must not jump to conclusions. Childeuk was a member of the Jin Family household, someone he ought to trust and cherish.

Jin Wikyung forcibly erased his suspicions and spoke.

"I've heard a lot about you."

"Y-You have, sir?"

"Of course. I've been keeping an eye on you for a long time."

More precisely, not for a long time, but for the past three days.

Jin Wikyung had been searching for a reliable servant to entrust with a very important task, and Childeuk was the ideal candidate he had personally selected.

"A talented man possessing all four virtues—benevolence, righteousness, propriety, and wisdom. That was you."

"How can this be…!"

Childeuk, an exceptional servant possessing all four virtues, shuddered with emotion. Completely illiterate, he had no idea what those four virtues meant, but he understood the word "talented" perfectly.

I'm talented?

He had been praised for being strong and diligent, but no one had ever called him talented. And now he was hearing it from none other than the Lesser Family Head himself, a man as lofty as the heavens.

Was this a dream or reality? Childeuk was swept up in overwhelming excitement. He was so excited that even his tongue became tangled.

"I've always been watching you too, Lesser Family Head!"

Jin Wikyung flinched.

What did I just hear?

"…What do you mean?"

"I've dreamed of this moment for a long time. The day I would stand behind you, Lesser Family Head!"

"Wait. That sounds strange. Why would you stand behind me?"

"Ah!"

Childeuk sucked in a breath. Jin Wikyung was telling him not to stand behind him. In other words, he wanted Childeuk to take the lead and win glory.

"Then I'll stand in front!"

"No! That's strange too!"

But Childeuk's charge, like a wild stallion, did not stop.

"I will gladly offer this one body of mine!"

Jin Wikyung's vision went dark.

"No. Don't do it! Don't offer it!"

"Lesser Family Head!"

Huff, huff.

Childeuk panted heavily, and Jin Wikyung gathered his internal energy.

I never imagined something like this would happen.

No matter how open-minded he was, this was too much.

Personal sexual preferences were one thing, but he had no desire to become their object. Jin Wikyung swallowed hard.

"Then… are you really into men?"[351]

Childeuk's eyes flashed. His heart pounded at the thought of wearing the navy-blue uniform of the Jin Family's martial artists.

"Yes! Just give the order!"

"How dare you set your sights on me? Not a chance, you bastard!"

Smack!

A slap from a Peak master was powerful. Childeuk collapsed like a puppet with its strings cut. Jin Wikyung stared down at him, breathing hard, then hurriedly rang the bell.

Ding. Ding.

"Lesser Family Head, did you call—? Gasp! Childeuk!"

Jin Wikyung spoke to the horrified servant.

"Drag him out immediately!"

"W-What happened?"

"That bastard tried to… No. Never mind."

He could not possibly say such a thing to a member of his household. For the first time in his life, anger and wounded sorrow brought him close to tears.

"I-I'll take care of it."

Just as the quick-witted servant hoisted Childeuk onto his back, Jin Wikyung added the most important part.

"And that man."

"Yes?"

"Remove him from his post."

"Ah."

The servant suddenly remembered Childeuk's assignment.

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[351] In Korean, *nam-saek* can refer both to male homosexuality and to the color navy blue, creating the misunderstanding between Jin Wikyung and Childeuk.

Delivering meals.

The most important duty given to Childeuk, an exceptional servant possessing all four virtues, was to bring every meal to Jin Mukyung and Jin Taekyung.

“Don’t let him anywhere near my younger brothers. Understood?”

“Yes, sir!”

Training Day 1

I decided to start keeping a diary today.

So I won’t forget what I learn during this training.

Under Jin Mukyung’s guidance, I did nothing but swing a spear all day. Every day begins and ends with a spar. I got beaten half to death, but it’s bearable.

This is my first time grinding ink, and it’s surprisingly fun.

Training Day 2

I swung my spear to the point of death again today. Maybe that’s why my Strength and Stamina stats increased, and the Jin Family’s Spear Technique reached the ninth stage.

I’m progressing much faster than when I trained alone, but I can’t help thinking I’d be better off spending this time learning another Peak martial art.

Still, Jin Mukyung must have his reasons.

Grinding ink is getting a little annoying. I’m tired.

Training Day 3

The Jin Family’s Spear Technique again. I asked him to teach me another martial art and got beaten half to death. He said my mind was rotten.

While desperately dodging his attacks, the Jin Family’s Manoeuvre Technique rose to the eighth stage. Damn it. This is surprisingly effective.

Training Day 4

I haven’t slept more than two hours a day since training began.

Most of my time is spent repeating the same cycle with Jin Mukyung: training, sparring, training, sparring. Starting yesterday, I began using fasting pills instead of wasting time eating.

Even with the System, I’m starting to reach my physical limit.

Training Day 5

My arms hurt, so I only ground a little ink.

The sky is yellow.

Going to sleep.

Training Day 6

I don’t understand why the System doesn’t have a notepad function.

I got pissed off while grinding ink and broke the inkstone. Jin Mukyung beat me.

Training Day 7

The Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique reached the ninth stage. My Level also increased by one.

I've practiced it so relentlessly that these days, I even use the footwork when I'm just walking around.

I got goose bumps.

Training Day 8

My hands and feet keep getting tangled today. It feels like these aren't the martial arts I know anymore.

The martial arts I've performed thousands—even tens of thousands—of times feel unfamiliar. Jin Mukyung said it was a natural phenomenon.

What the hell is he talking about?

I got beaten because my expression was disrespectful.

Training Day 9

I think I get it.

Bang!

Compressed air erupted from the tip of the wooden spear. Jin Mukyung skidded backward and clicked his tongue as he looked at his broken sword.

"That was a narrow success."

I did not answer. I stood there blankly, gripping my spear.

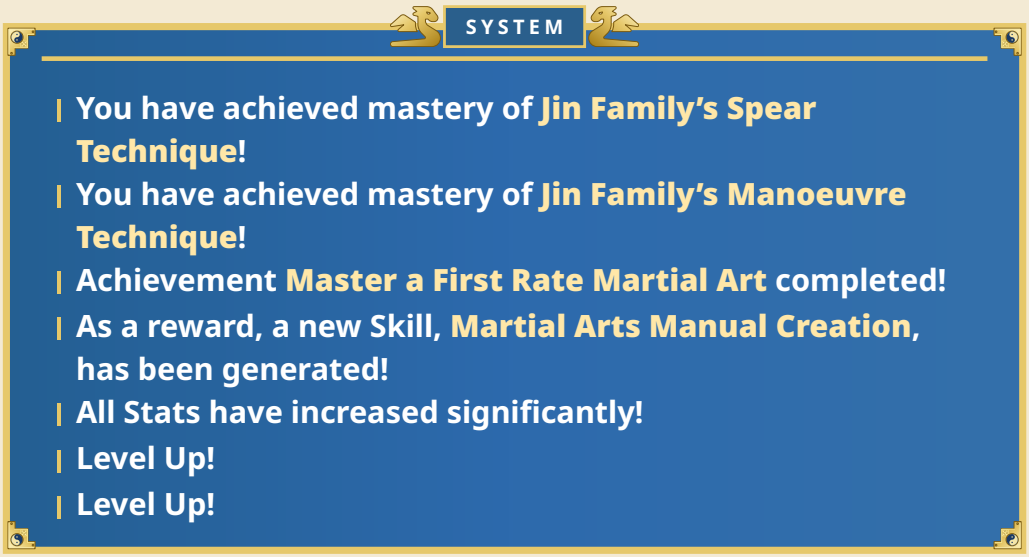
So this is what it was.

I had thought I knew the martial arts I'd learned inside and out. But I was wrong. I had merely mistaken the middle of the mountain for the summit.

Whenever my martial arts rose to a new level, a new landscape came into view.

Just like now.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



A wave of System notifications swept over me.

Chapter 73

Ding. Ding. Ding.

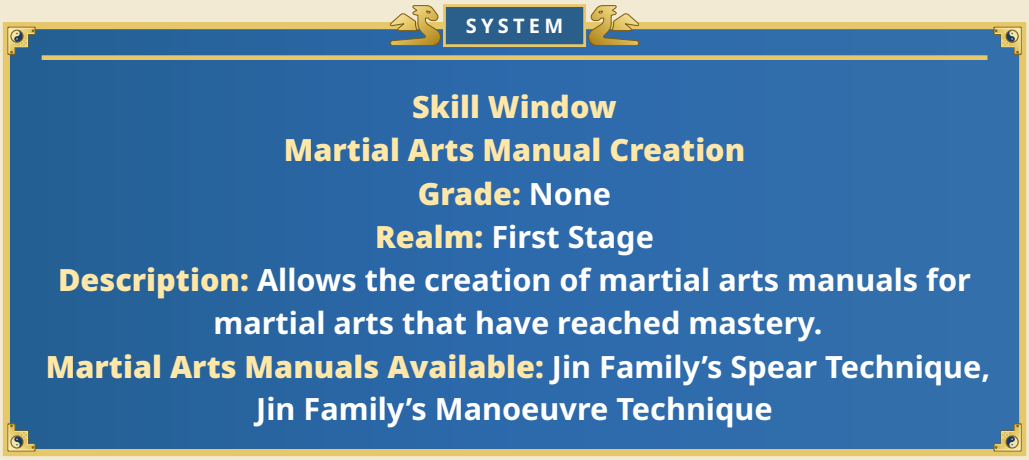
The flood of System notifications was enough to make my ears hurt. My mouth fell open as I dismissed the message windows filling my vision one by one.

Why are there so many rewards?

Two Level Ups, an increase to all my Stats, and a new Skill for completing an achievement.

Martial Arts Manual Creation?

Ding.



The description confirmed exactly what I had guessed.

It's a Skill, so I guess it's better than nothing…

For now, though, it did not seem particularly useful. I was mostly fascinated that the System would give me a production Skill like this.

This really does feel like a game sometimes.

There were still far too many things in this world that I had never experienced.

Everything was unfamiliar and unreal. Even now, I still could not tell whether Murim was a game or another reality altogether.

Smack!

"Ah."

I turned around, clutching the back of my stinging head. Jin Mukyung stood there holding a wooden sword broken in half, staring at me like I was pathetic.

"Not concentrating?"

"Seriously. Why do you keep hitting me in the head? It's annoying."

"You bastard. You're slipping back into casual speech again."

Jin Mukyung narrowed his eyes, but he was not very frightening anymore.

It's not like I've only been hit once or twice.

Today marked the tenth day since the hellish training began.

I had realized one important fact right from the start.

I get hit even when I use polite speech!

I had been beaten black and blue. I had even gained the **Toughness** Stat on only the second day, which said everything that needed saying. No matter what I did, I was going to get beaten anyway. I might as well speak casually and claim the moral victory.

Smack!

"That barely tickles."

The Toughness Stat had not appeared for nothing.

Just as flowers grew with sunlight and water, my Stats had flourished under merciless violence and hellish training.

Whack!

"Hey, wait. You hit bone. Bone."

"The spar isn't over."

Thud-thud-thud!

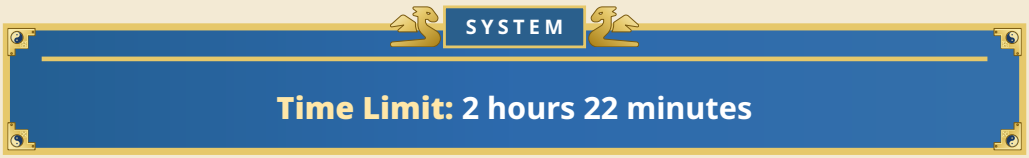
While taking hits from the wooden sword as it struck my vital points with practiced precision, I swung my spear as well.

Sshh-shh-shhk! Crack!

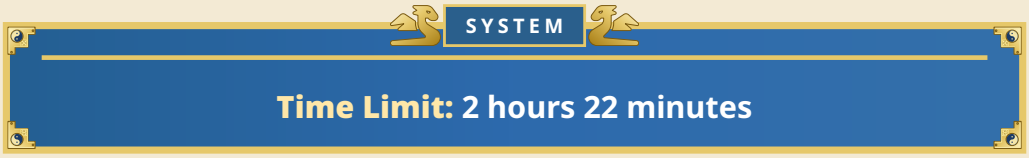
Ten days of hellish training.

At last, the Jin Family's Spear Technique and Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique, both brought to mastery, flowed from me as naturally as breathing.

Ding.



Ding.



"…?"

What the hell? Why did it ring twice?

Sshh-shh-shhk!

Clang!

As he blocked the spear bearing down on him, Jin Mukyung swallowed the laugh threatening to escape.

Look at this bastard.

Ten days. Short in some ways, long in others. But when that was all the time it had taken to master a First Rate martial art, it became another matter entirely.

What kind of bastard is this?

He had thought the same thing dozens of times over the past ten days. Jin Taekyung's rate of growth went beyond even the saying "hear one, know ten."

Knowing something and making it your own are different.

Mastering a martial art meant understanding it perfectly and being able to execute it. Jin Taekyung had made two First Rate martial arts completely his own in only ten days.

Even taking into account the fact that he had already reached a certain level, this was an astonishing achievement.

So this really is possible.

Jin Mukyung was dumbfounded. What had his initial estimate been again?

One thing was certain: Taekyung had far surpassed his original goal.

All I meant to do was cure him of that habit of throwing out his hands and feet whenever he felt like it, then make sure his fundamentals were solid…

But once training began, things had changed.

Fundamentals? Jin Mukyung had no way of knowing, but Jin Taekyung had trained relentlessly for seven years. Training to grow stronger. Struggling desperately to survive.

His palms had split open and healed dozens of times, and with every cycle, his spear had grown faster and stronger. As a result, there was nothing to criticize in Jin Taekyung's fundamentals beyond a few minor problems with his posture.

The same goes for everything else.

Horse-stance[352] training would have been nothing but a waste of time.

Strength, Stamina, Agility—every one of his physical abilities far surpassed those of martial artists at the same level, and all of them had developed with remarkable balance.

So it wasn't sheer luck that kept him alive until now.

Look at that tall, lanky frame and those long limbs. Those lean, compact muscles. Was this really the same skinny brat who had worked on his abs three years ago to impress courtesans?

Damn it. It's not like he has the Heavenly Martial Physique.

Jin Mukyung was once again struck by the sheer absurdity of it all when—

Swoooosh!

[352]Horse stance is a martial-arts training posture with the feet set wide and the knees bent.

A spear thrust forward with powerful momentum.

Jin Mukyung used his footwork to retreat, but Jin Taekyung pursued him relentlessly, pressing the attack.

Sshk! Sshh-shh-shhk!

Even the same martial art changed depending on who wielded it and how. Every move carried the wielder's temperament and disposition.

The Jin Family's Spear Technique Jin Mukyung was using now was no different.

Was this what the Jin Family's Spear Technique was supposed to be?

Martial artist and wandering martial artist. Movements that had been awkward and uneasy in some indefinable way were gradually beginning to harmonize.

He's already made it his own.

Ten days ago, Jin Taekyung had been half-finished, but the change had already begun. Jin Mukyung was proud of his younger brother's achievement. At the same time, heat began to build in his stomach.

This is…

He had felt this emotion once before toward someone else. He had never dreamed Jin Taekyung would become its object.

Jealousy. And competitive spirit.

Jin Mukyung froze in place.

Toward that momentary opening, the final form of the Jin Family's Spear Technique—Sky-Piercing Strike—shot forward.

"Haap!"

Whoooosh!

The wind spiraling around the spear swallowed Jin Taekyung's shout. Just as the spear seemed about to pierce Jin Mukyung's chest, his hand closed around his sword hilt.

Fwoosh!

A flash erupted from his waist and cleaved through the wind.

At its end stood Jin Taekyung.

Sshk!

A short rush of wind swept past, and my upper body suddenly felt breezy. My martial arts uniform had been sliced cleanly open from my right waist to my left shoulder, letting the chilly air of the underground training ground seep through the gap.

Only after confirming that I was unhurt did I let out a sigh of relief.

"Whew."

Sword Energy out of nowhere? My heart had nearly jumped out of my throat.

“Crazy. You said you weren’t going to use Sword Energy.”

“…Only an idiot would take that at face value.”

Jin Mukyung answered with a distinctly uneasy expression and sheathed his sword.

“Training ends here.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Jin Mukyung has declared the training complete.
The remaining Time Limit has vanished.
Quest success will be determined by Jin Mukyung’s evaluation.

Success? Or failure?

Under my expectant gaze, he opened his mouth.

“You’ve still got a long way to go.”

“Ah.”

“To think this is all you managed to keep up with after ten days. What a waste of my ti—”

Jin Mukyung broke off with a sour expression.

“What’s with that look?”

“Huh? What?”

“That bizarre expression you’re making right now!”

“I’m not making one. I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

But Jin Mukyung was right.

I was struggling desperately to keep the corners of my mouth from rising. The reason was the System message floating in the air.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have fulfilled the conditions for Quest success!
Quest Training? Trial! has been completed!
Level Up!
The Quest completion Reward has been moved to your Inventory!
Excellent work. An additional Reward will be granted!

“Hm. You’re a shy child, aren’t you?”

Jin Mukyung. An honest young man.

“You bastard! What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

“Forget it. Twenty-three is a bashful age.”

“You little—”

Jin Mukyung’s eyes went wild, and he was about to charge at me when—

Creak.

The door leading to the surface opened, and a servant cautiously poked his head inside.

“Um, Young Masters?”

He was the servant who had regularly brought us meals until about three days ago. Something had clearly happened since we last saw him. His face was covered in bruises, and four or five of his teeth were broken.

He continued speaking through the gaps in his teeth.

“The Lesser Family Head is looking for you.”

“…Damn it.”

Jin Mukyung looked back and forth between Childeuk and me, then reluctantly lowered his fist.

We followed Childeuk. Jin Mukyung walked along with a sour expression, staring only at the ground as if everything offended him. Childeuk kept groaning whenever pain shot through him with each step.

“Ow. Good grief. Urgh.”

“…”

That was seriously getting on my nerves.

“How did you get hurt?”

“There was a minor misunderstanding.”

Those looked like fairly serious injuries for a minor misunderstanding.

In the modern world, potions meant there was nothing that could not be healed. Murim was different. I clicked my tongue as I looked at Childeuk’s broken teeth.

“That must hurt.”

“It’s all right.”

Childeuk puffed out his chest with stoic resolve.

“A martial artist of the Jin Family of Taiyuan must be able to endure this much.”

“…”

He had been acting like he was about to die from the pain just moments ago.

But wasn’t this man a servant?

Come to think of it, his clothes have changed.

He was wearing the dark navy martial arts uniform worn by martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I thought he had been wearing a servant’s clothes before.

Noticing my gaze, he smiled shyly.

“Oh. I officially became a martial artist a few days ago.”

“A martial artist?”

Jin Mukyung, who had been walking silently behind us, suddenly spoke.

“Under whose command?”

I might have made a name for myself lately, but I was still nowhere near as famous as Jin Mukyung. Childeuk answered with an awestruck expression.

“I serve directly under the Lesser Family Head.”

“Only specially selected martial artists in our family are allowed to serve directly under our eldest brother.”

Jin Mukyung looked Childeuk up and down. His gaze was not contemptuous so much as assessing, as though he were measuring Childeuk’s realm.

“Your physique is decent, but you don’t seem to have learned any martial arts.”

“Yes. To be honest, I’m bewildered myself. I’ve never properly performed so much as a single form.”

According to my **Qi Sense**, Childeuk was Level 12. That was high for a servant who had done nothing but carry food, but by martial-artist standards, he was Third Rate.

The First Rate masters directly under Jin Wikyung are all above Level 40.

What was going on? Did he have powerful backing?

Jin Mukyung seemed to have reached the same conclusion. His brow furrowed.

“You must have good connections. What does your father do?”

Childeuk blinked his large, calf-like eyes.

“He died ten years ago.”

“…”

“…”

“He was a famous herb gatherer, but he was killed by a tiger.”

For a moment, my vision went hazy. Befitting a Peak master, Jin Mukyung was the first to regain his composure and hurriedly tried to smooth things over.

“H-He must have been an excellent man.”

“Even now, I remember him as a very innocent man. He and my mother were very loving, too.”

“Then your mother… perhaps? No—she isn’t, right?”

“She’s doing well.”

Just as we breathed sighs of relief, Childeuk gazed wistfully at a distant mountain.

“I buried her beside my father, so I’m sure they’re both doing well.”

“…”

“…”

What followed was a march of death. I wanted to run away at full speed, but I gave up after hearing Childeuk muttering to himself.

“Oh, I haven’t seen those flowers in a long time. I used to see them everywhere when I went into the mountains with my father.”

“…”

“…”

If we had walked with him for another fifteen minutes, Jin Mukyung might have killed himself. Fortunately, after five minutes that felt like five hours, we reached our destination.

“Oh, you’re here!”

The sight of Jin Wikyung waiting in front of the pavilion nearly brought tears to my eyes. We cried out in voices thick with emotion.

“Hyuung![353]”

“Hyung-nim![354]”

Childeuk awkwardly clasped his hands in a formal salute.

“As ordered, I have escorted the Young Masters here.”

Jin Wikyung had been hurrying toward Jin Mukyung and me, but he suddenly stopped and embraced Childeuk instead.

“Jang Childeuk, a man of benevolence, righteousness, propriety, and wisdom! Martial Artist Jang, you’ve returned!”

“Yes, sir, Lesser Family Head!”

“You’ve completed a very important mission! Go and rest now.”

What on earth was happening? Jin Mukyung and I stared blankly at the scene.

Then a voice reached my ear through Sound Transmission.

There was, uh, a minor misunderstanding between me and this fellow…

“…”

Somehow, I had a feeling I knew who was backing Childeuk.

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[353] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or older male acquaintance. *Hyung-nim* adds a respectful suffix.

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Chapter 74

"You've changed."

Those were the first words Jin Wikyung spoke after we entered his office. He studied me carefully, then patted Jin Mukyung on the shoulder.

"You've worked hard."

But despite the warm words, Jin Mukyung answered with a sullen expression.

"I almost called a mortician."

"You really know how to say beautiful things."

"You—whew. I'm letting that slide because Hyung-nim[355] is here."

"Thank you for that too."

Jin Wikyung gave a short laugh and gestured for us to sit. I took a seat, sipped the warm tea, and looked around.

"This place has changed a lot too. It was a mess the last time I was here."

The office was neat and orderly. When I had last visited fifteen days ago, the place had been a disaster, with all kinds of things strewn everywhere.

Now, even the table that should have been buried beneath stacks of documents was spotless.

"…It was a difficult time."

Jin Wikyung muttered with a clouded expression.

"But it's almost over. Just a little longer. I only have to hold out a little longer."

"…"

This guy had lost half his mind too. Then again, he had handled that enormous workload all by himself. It would have been stranger if he were still perfectly sane.

If it were me, I would've fled in the middle of the night ages ago.

I was no exception, but martial artists were, to put it kindly, men of action and, to put it unkindly, blockheads. I wasn't trying to disparage them. That was simply the truth.

The senior members of the family were much the same.

Some of that might have been because the Head Elder had installed puppets, but even the senior members who sided with Jin Wikyung were far from capable administrators.

Jin Wikyung had been born into a prestigious martial family, yet he was both a skilled administrator and an outstanding martial artist. In other words, he was the oddity.

"Just one day. I want to rest for just one day. I want to rest. I want to rest."

---

[355] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

As Jin Wikyung muttered the same words over and over like a man with obsessive-compulsive disorder, Jin Mukyung clicked his tongue.

“Thank goodness I was born second.”

I nodded.

“Agreed.”

Taking care of my family in the real world was already backbreaking. If I had entered Jin Wikyung’s body instead of Jin Taekyung’s when I first logged in…

It would have been nothing short of bleak.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan even had hundreds of retainers under its command. The only advantage was that, as the homeowner, I wouldn’t have to worry about my jeonse deposit[356] going up.

“The eldest son is supposed to carry a heavy burden.”

Jin Mukyung snorted at my words.

“You have no right to say that, so shut up. Isn’t that right, Hyung-nim[357]?”

Jin Wikyung stared at me with moist eyes.

“How does he always manage to pick such touching things to say?”

“No, Hyung-nim[358].”

“You’ve grown up. You really have.”

“…Can I curse at him?”

Despite Jin Mukyung’s icy words, Jin Wikyung seemed not to hear a thing. Still deeply moved, he spread both arms wide.

“Let me hug our youngest just once.”

“Yes, hyung[359].”

“My youngest!”

Whump!

Jin Mukyung muttered with a face like he had bitten into something foul.

“This damned household. See if I ever come back.”

“Mukyung, you come here too.”

“No. I won’t, even if you beat me to death.”

“We’ve all gathered in one place for once, and you can’t grant your only older brother’s request?”

Jin Mukyung flinched at the hurt in his voice.

---

[356] A *jeonse* lease is a Korean rental arrangement in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent.

[357] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

[358] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

[359] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

"…Just this once."

The instant the words left his mouth, a hand as large as a pot lid dragged him in.

Buried against Jin Wikyung's chest alongside me, Jin Mukyung silently mouthed:

"You. Are. Dead."

Hmm. I'd better stay out of sight for a while.

Apparently he would be leaving soon anyway. I only had to avoid him for a few days.

If things get too bad, I can always log out.

I had completed the Quest, and I had already been thinking it was about time to return. There was also the matter of my contract with Team Leader Choi. More than anything, I was itching to test my newly refined martial arts in a Gate.

"Thank you. You two have given me strength."

After ending the emotional embrace, Jin Wikyung dabbed at his eyes with his sleeve.

"There's just so much work. So much work."

"…"

He really must have been suffering.

The tears of a human weapon made me solemn in spite of myself. I patted Jin Wikyung on the back.

"Hang in there."

Jin Mukyung, who had looked like death until moments ago, also gave Jin Wikyung a sympathetic look.

"Hyung-nim[360]. If it's really that difficult, take this guy and put him to work."

"…?"

What the hell was he talking about? Dumbfounded, I asked,

"Usually, at a time like this, shouldn't you at least say, 'I'll help,' even if you don't mean it?"

Jin Mukyung answered confidently.

"A martial artist does not make empty promises."

"Then why drag me into it while I'm sitting here?"

"You have plenty of time."

"I don't!"

"I have even less. I need to train. Besides, I'm hopeless with paperwork."

"I was in the seventh tier at school![361]"

"What nonsense is that?"

"It means I was terrible at studying."

---

[360] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

[361] Korean school grades use a nine-tier scale, with the first tier highest and the ninth lowest.

Jin Mukyung thought for a moment, then frowned.

“A completely useless bastard. Hyung-nim[362], he does have good strength, so he would make an excellent laborer. I’ll be going now.”

“Wait.”

As Jin Mukyung swiftly turned to leave, a giant forepaw—no, hand—caught him by the nape. Its owner was, naturally, Jin Wikyung.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

“Pardon?”

“You have to hear why I called you two before you leave.”

“…What is it?”

Unease crept across Jin Mukyung’s face. I didn’t have a mirror, but I was probably wearing the same expression.

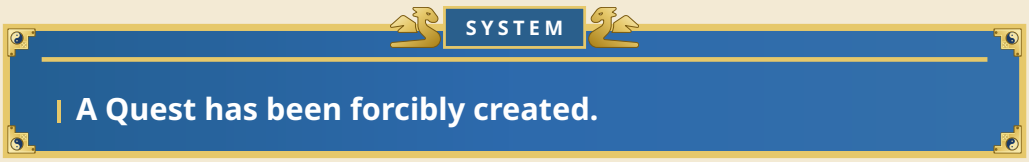
I smell trouble.

I had an uncanny nose for this sort of thing.

The smell of bad luck. The premonition that something bothersome was about to happen. Jin Wikyung’s next words turned that premonition into certainty.

“I need you to go to the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

Ding.



“…”

Goddammit. Now it doesn’t even ask.

I stared at the translucent Quest window.

[362] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male he is close to. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

SYSTEM

Quest
[Yesterday's Enemy, Today's Ally]
Now that the full truth has been revealed, the Mount Heng Sword Sect is no longer an enemy, but an ally with whom you must join hands. Invite them to the Jin Family of Taiyuan for the upcoming New Year's Day.
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Deliver the invitation (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: None

After reading it two or three times, my initial bewilderment had mostly subsided.

Not bad.

The Quest wasn't difficult, and there was no penalty for failure. It was a simple mission that would end as soon as I delivered the invitation.

More importantly…

Logout.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Would you like to log out?

That meant I could log out without any problems. Having a Quest forced on me still left a bad taste in my mouth, but this much was acceptable.

Not that I'm in a position to refuse anyway.

Unlike me, who had already accepted reality, Jin Mukyung was resisting with all his might.

"So…"

Jin Mukyung struggled to continue.

"You're saying we should invite the Mount Heng Sword Sect for the coming New Year's Day?"

Jin Wikyung answered,

"Yes. They are guests we cannot afford to miss."

"Then why do we—or rather, why do I—have to go?"

"…"

Look at him, struggling to exclude himself.

Still, I agreed with part of his question.

Why us, specifically?

Jin Wikyung's answer only made the question even bigger.

"The Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect requested it personally."

I blurted out a question before I could stop myself.

"The Sect Leader?"

I had watched the Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek die right before my eyes. Lee Seogeun, the Second Young Master, had been poisoned, and the Young Sect Leader whom I had never even met had reportedly died an absurd death during a mounted-bandit raid on the undefended sect.

I thought the Mount Heng Sword Sect's main force had been wiped out at Eight Spring Gorge too.

But the Sect Leader?

Jin Mukyung's reaction was much the same.

"The damage must have been severe. I only heard about it through rumors, but wouldn't it be understandable if they closed the sect's gates?"

Jin Wikyung shook his head.

"They were once one of the pillars of Shanxi Murim. Don't underestimate their foundations. If they have a rallying point, they can aim for a revival."

A rallying point.

The new Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect—the person who had requested that Jin Wikyung send Mukyung and me—seemed to be that new rallying point. I asked:

"Who is it?"

"Lee Seowol."

"Lee Seowol? Lee Seowol…"

I had never heard the name before. Judging by the surname, there seemed to be some connection to Lee Cheonbaek.

"You don't remember the name?"

"A hidden son? A distant relative? I'm not sure."

"As expected, you don't remember."

"Pardon?"

What did he mean, I didn't remember?

Is that someone I know?

As I tilted my head, Jin Wikyung gave me an odd look.

"The new Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect is a woman. She is Lee Cheonbaek's third child, the one and only younger sister of the deceased Young Sect Leader and Lee Seogeun."

At that moment, a fragment of memory flashed through my mind.

The stage in my memory was the main arena. The actor was Lee Seogeun. His face was flushed bright red as he shouted at me:

"You shameless bastard! You tore my sister's clothes and tried to violate her!"

Ah!

"Don't tell me it's her."

"That's right."

"…Damn it."

Only Jin Mukyung, who had no idea what we were talking about, blinked in confusion.

"What does that mean? Hey, do you know her?"

"Uh, well. You could say I do, and you could also say I don't."

"What the hell does that mean? So what exactly is your relationship with her?"

"Hmm."

An ex-girlfriend whose face I've never even seen? Or a flower snake?[363]

One thing is certain.

Neither of us would be particularly happy to meet the other.

I let out a deep sigh.

Long story short, Jin Mukyung agreed to go to the Mount Heng Sword Sect too. Jin Wikyung had used the masterstroke he had been saving.

"I heard the Mount Heng Sword Sect has a lot of martial arts manuals…"

"Even if they do, what good is that? It's not like I can read them."

"It does matter."

"Pardon?"

"The new Sect Leader has you figured out. She said she'd be willing to show you some of their Peak martial arts if you came."

"…When are we leaving?"

"Right now."

Everything moved at lightning speed. It had been only two hours since Jin Wikyung saw us off and we climbed into the four-horse carriage.

Jin Mukyung sat across from me, grumbling.

"A carriage? It'll take forever just to get there."

The land was so vast that, even by a rough estimate, it would take three days to reach Eung-hyeon, where the Mount Heng Sword Sect was located.

For Jin Mukyung, who wanted to see the Mount Heng Sword Sect's Peak martial arts as soon as possible, three days was an eternity.

[363] *Flower snake* is Korean slang for a woman who seduces men to exploit them.

“Hey, coachman, can’t you go any faster?”

A reply came from the driver’s box beyond the partition.

“First of all, I’m not the coachman. And no, I can’t go any faster. You may not know this from inside, but it’s freezing out here, and I’m about to freeze to death. Anyway, that’s how things are.”

“Use the whip and spur the horses on! A coachman should be able to do at least that much.”

“I’ll say it again: I’m not the coachman. Also, the whip is frozen solid, so it would be more accurate to call it an icicle. If I jab the horses in the rear with this icicle, I think they’ll get very angry…”

“What? If you’re not the coachman, why are you sitting there?”

“Before we left, you shouted that the attendants were getting in your way and ordered everyone to get lost. The coachman got lost too.”

Jin Mukyung thought about it carefully, then smacked his forehead.

“Oh, right.”

“…”

As expected, this guy wasn’t normal either.

“Then who are you?”

Recalling the law of conservation of idiots, I answered,

“Hyuk Mujin.”

“Who’s Hyuk Mujin?”

“You’ll know when you see his face. Hey, Mujin!”

The partition slid down, revealing Hyuk Mujin’s frost-covered face. His teeth chattered nonstop as Jin Mukyung studied him closely, then snapped his fingers.

“Oh, that guy.”

Hyuk Mujin answered curtly,

“Yes. I’m that guy.”

“Then why didn’t you get lost too? You should’ve brought the coachman instead.”

As if he had been waiting for that question, Hyuk Mujin proudly puffed out his chest.

“I only obey my Captain’s orders.”

“Captain?”

“The Third Young Master.”

Jin Mukyung’s head snapped toward me.

“Did you call him?”

“No. He was already there without me calling him.”

“That’s what he says?”

Hyuk Mujin looked back and forth between us with a wounded expression.

“You two really are brothers, I suppose.”

“Did you say your name was Hyung Mujin? Explain exactly what you mean by that.”

Jin Mukyung bristled and spoke in a sharp voice, but I merely let out a long yawn.

Hyuk Mujin clowning around was nothing new; when it came to dealing with that, I already had a full jiazi[364] of internal energy.

“It’s not Hyung Mujin. It’s Hyuk Mujin. I’ll try jabbing the horses in the rear with this thing, whether it’s a whip or an icicle.”

Clack.

Jin Mukyung glared at the partition, which had quickly slammed shut, then sighed and settled back into his seat.

“I shouldn’t have expected anything. If the water upstream is filthy, how could the water downstream be clean… What are you doing?”

I wrapped a fur hide around myself as I answered,

“I’m going to circulate my qi.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. Circulate my qi.”

“Then why does it look to me like you’re getting ready to sleep?”

“You’re imagining things.”

“Then why are you covering yourself with a fur hide?”

“I get cold easily.”

I made a show of sitting cross-legged. I also pressed myself firmly against the carriage wall so I wouldn’t topple over.

I can’t entrust my precious body to that guy.

I absolutely refused to come back and find my arms or legs broken. Better to make sure he couldn’t touch me at all.

“You know what happens if you touch me, right? Huh? Do you know what qi deviation is or not?”

“Seriously, this bastard’s been getting on my nerves for a while now…”

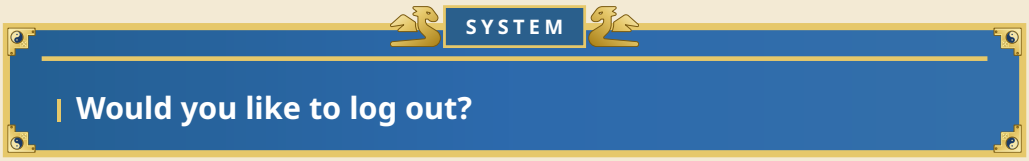
The moment Jin Mukyung raised his fist, I hurriedly closed my eyes. From the outside, it would look as though I had begun circulating my qi. As expected, no fist came flying at me.

All right, then. Now…

Logout.

Ding.

[364] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.



There was only one possible answer.

Chapter 75

The way to tell the modern world apart from Murim is, oddly enough, by smell and temperature.

The smell of sweat inside a VR helmet. The heat inside a capsule warmed just right by sunlight streaming through the window.

“Phew.”

Once I took off the helmet and climbed out of the capsule, I finally felt like I could breathe. It was still only the difference between a scalding bath and a hot one, though.

How much time has passed?

I checked the watch on my wrist. The cheap twelve-thousand-won[365] digital watch I’d bought from a street stall in front of the Hunter training center about seven years ago had the advantage of an alarm and a stopwatch.

Beep.

[02:05:35]

Two hours, five minutes, and thirty-five seconds.

I had spent around twenty days in Murim, so the timing roughly matched what had happened last time.

Now that I’m back in the modern world, the time ratio must have reversed.

With Logout complete, ten days in the modern world amounted to one hour in Murim. I washed up in the goshiwon’s[366] communal shower and returned to my room.

Just as I was about to close the door, a black shadow sprang up.

“Boo!”

Knew it. Of course it was Seong Jinho.

“Oh. My. God. What. A. Surprise.”

“…What’s with that reaction? You knew I was here?”

“Your inhales and exhales were extremely intense. Mr. Jinho, were you excited?”

My five senses had grown sharper with each passing day. I could pick up the sounds and movements around me without even using Qi Sense.

He seemed to have been keeping his breathing quiet as he waited, but to my ears, every tiny movement and breath he made sounded like thunder.

“Try breathing a little more quietly. You’re supposed to be the goshiwon[367] manager. It’d be a problem if people started filing noise complaints about you.”

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[365] Twelve thousand Korean won is about $8.60 or €7.70 at the project conversion rates.

[366] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

[367] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

“Damn it. How did you know? You’re just an F-rank Hunter… Oh, right. You became C-rank a while ago.”

“Listen to you. Making fun of me for being F-rank has really become a habit.”

“Hey, wait until you’re my age. I can’t even remember what side dishes I ate yesterday. You think something that happened barely a week ago is going to pop right into my head?”

“A week?”

Was that really all the time that had passed?

To me, it had been well over a month. To Jinho-hyung,[368] it had happened just last week. I felt a subtle sense of disconnect.

“Hey. What’s with that look? Is something wrong?”

“Nothing’s wrong. Anyway, what brings you here?”

“Listen to the way you talk. Are we in some kind of business relationship where we only see each other when there’s business involved?”

“Just get to the point. Keep it short.”

Jinho-hyung’s[369] face hardened. Had I taken the teasing too far?

Come to think of it, I had been too indifferent lately. Even before returning to Murim, I hadn’t been able to see him often because of all sorts of problems…

“Buy me dinner.”

“…”

“Grilled pork belly. Teppanyaki.[370] Fried chicken and beer.”

Shit. Of course.

And he even had the nerve to choose the menu himself.

“Did you leave money with me?”

“Your money is my money. And my money is my money, isn’t it?”

“Pronounce that properly. Unless you want a taste of a C-rank Hunter’s fist.”

Jinho-hyung[371] flinched and rubbed his palms together.

“Please, sir. Use your money to grease my parched stomach.”

“…”

That stance switch would make Udyr[372] weep.

It was ridiculous, but a quiet laugh escaped me. My stomach had also been screaming after nearly a month without a proper meal.

Let’s eat something decent for once.

I spoke in a solemn voice.

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[368] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[369] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[370] Teppanyaki is food cooked on an iron griddle.
[371] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[372] Udyr is a *League of Legends* character known for switching between combat stances.

"I approve of your attitude. Lead the way."

"Where would you like to go, sir?"

"I'm tired of grilled pork belly and teppanyaki.[373] Let's have something a little more expensive today."

"Th-then, sir!"

Jinho-hyung's[374] eyes widened.

"Hanwoo![375] That pasture-raised beef with the incredible marbling?"

"What the hell are you talking about? We're going out for gopchang.[376]"

"…"

"If you don't like it, starve."

Thump.

Jinho-hyung[377] grabbed my shoulder and declared with a solemn expression, "I've always wanted to try it."

Our early dinner began at five that afternoon and ended at a makgeolli[378] bar on our third round. By then, Jinho-hyung[379] was completely plastered.

"Krroooorr."

"…"

I had seen this scene somewhere before.

As a strange sense of déjà vu came over me and I hoisted Jinho-hyung[380] onto my back, my phone rang.

> └ **Designer-Brand Junkie:** See you tomorrow at the same time, same place.

A single short text. The sender was Team Leader Choi.

The downside—and upside—of Sleep Mode was that it reduced how much sleep I needed. Except when I'd been badly injured in the fight with Jopil, I had never slept for more than three hours.

It's useful for training.

Three in the morning.

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[373] Teppanyaki is food cooked on an iron griddle.
[374] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[375] Hanwoo is a Korean breed of native cattle whose beef is prized for its marbling.
[376] Gopchang is a Korean dish made from grilled intestines, usually beef intestines.
[377] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[378] Makgeolli is a Korean alcoholic drink made from fermented rice.
[379] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[380] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.

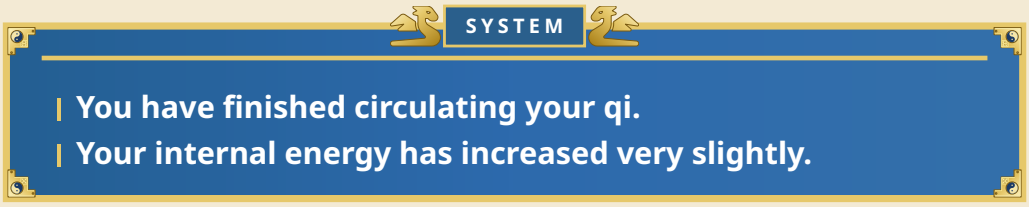
I woke up in peak condition and sat cross-legged. At some point, circulating my qi had become how I began and ended every day.

Whoosh.

A wave of internal energy began to flow.

The fifteen years of internal energy surging from my dantian cleansed the waste accumulated inside my body and breathed vitality into dormant acupoints.

Ding.



When the System notification sounded and I opened my eyes, more than two hours had passed. If I were in Murim, I would have gone straight to the training ground to warm up, but the real world came with all sorts of restrictions.

Especially in a goshiwon,[381] where the rooms were packed together like a chicken farm.

Damn goshiwon.[382] *I need to get out of here soon.*

Even training cost money these days. People who earned enough had several spacious private training rooms, while broke people like me had no choice but to make do with lousy conditions.

“Hup. Huff.”

I spent the entire morning running through the neighborhood. When I returned, I moved straight into basic bodyweight exercises without taking a break. Maybe it was because my Stats had increased, but instead of getting tired, I felt more energized by the minute.

Jinho-hyung[383] watched me with an appalled expression.

“Don’t you ever get tired?”

“Not really.”

“I’ve never seen anyone do one-arm push-ups as easily as you. How many have you done?”

“I don’t know. I counted to three hundred, then got too lazy to keep counting.”

“You’re a monster. Is that normal for a C-rank Hunter?”

“By the way, Seong Jinho.”

“Huh?”

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[381] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

[382] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

[383] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.

"Why are you here?"

Jinho-hyung[384] had shown up about ten minutes earlier looking haggard, and he still hadn't left my room.

"Can't you tell? I came to eat ramen."

Tap tap. Ssshhk.

The way he dropped a raw egg onto the almost-cooked noodles looked completely natural.

His control of the burner flame to leave the egg perfectly runny was worthy of a Peak master.

"Give me three reasons why you need to stuff your face with that in here."

"First, there's no TV in my room. Second, there's a TV in your room. Third, ramen tastes best when you eat it while watching TV."

He rattled it all off without hesitation, and my blood started boiling.

"Just buy one! If you don't have the money, just take mine!"

"Ah, I'd rather not. I'm leaving soon anyway. Why bother adding to my luggage?"

"Then stop coming in and out of here and bothering me… Huh? What did you just say?"

"What?"

"Wait. You're leaving?"

"Ah, that."

Jinho-hyung[385] scratched his matted hair.

"It just worked out that way. The date isn't set yet, but I'm planning to move out soon. I can't stay holed up here forever."

"…"

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"No, it's nothing."

I awkwardly looked away.

Who lived in a goshiwon[386] without a story of their own? I had mine, and Jinho-hyung[387] had his. It would be rude to pry.

Still, it's a shame.

He was someone I'd spent years with, like a friend and a brother. And now he was leaving so suddenly.

Caught up in complicated feelings, I cautiously opened my mouth.

"Hyung,[388] by any chance…"

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[384] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.

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[386] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

[387] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.

[388] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.

"I know how you feel, but I respectfully decline."

Had he realized what I was going to say? Jinho-hyung[389] cut me off decisively and continued.

"Kid, I'm thirty years old. I can take care of my own bowl."

"Then there's nothing I can do."

I'd thought I could probably live with Jinho-hyung,[390] but sticking my nose in too soon seemed to have pricked his pride.

His face scrunched up as he lifted the lid off the pot.

"You should've just said so from the start."

"What are you talking about? You never had any intention of it."

"What nonsense. I only cooked one because you said you weren't eating."

"…?"

Wait a second. How had the conversation ended up here?

After several seconds of silence, I finally asked, "What are you talking about? What's this about cooking something all of a sudden?"

"Obviously, ramen."

Jinho-hyung[391] glared at me menacingly.

"There's always someone who says he isn't eating, then asks for a chopstickful when you cook it well. How many times have I fallen for that one with you?"

"…"

"So a C-rank Hunter reaches into his poor hyung's[392] bowl? Are you even human?"

"…"

So when he'd mentioned his bowl earlier, he'd meant his actual bowl.

I wanted to throw his own words right back at him.

Is that thing even human?

I was a fucking idiot for thinking I could live with someone like him.

Ashamed of myself, I threw on some clothes. It was almost time to meet Team Leader Choi.

Bang!

I slammed the door hard enough to break it and left. One last shout rang out behind me.

"If you're going to the supermarket, get some kimchi!"

Ah, I wanted to kill him.

[389] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[390] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[391] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.
[392] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older man with whom he is close.

Where was the place again?

I dredged up my memories from about twenty days ago and arrived at the meeting place.

It was a large café in the heart of a forest of skyscrapers. A handsome man sitting by the window spotted me and waved.

“Over here.”

I didn’t need him to say anything. There were dozens of tables in the café, yet Team Leader Choi was the only customer sitting inside.

He’s still handsome.

Dressed in a lightweight casual suit, Team Leader Choi looked as though he had just stepped out of a fashion shoot. A successful man in his twenties who had everything: looks, money, personality…

No. Leave personality out of it.

After exchanging a brief handshake, we sat down.

“Have you eaten?”

“No.”

Team Leader Choi tilted his head.

“Really? You seem to have eaten ramen.”

“…”

Damn it. This bastard had a bloodhound’s nose.

It was too embarrassing to explain the whole story about what had happened at the goshiwon,[393] so I hurriedly changed the subject.

“It’s lunchtime, but no one’s here.”

“We’re closed.”

“What?”

“The windows are covered with curtains, and there’s a ‘Closed’ sign on the door. Of course no one’s coming in.”

I looked around. Sure enough, everything was exactly as Team Leader Choi had described.

I had assumed the café would be open since it was the meeting place, so I hadn’t noticed. The whole situation was so strange that I blinked.

“But you’re open right now.”

The lights inside were bright, and the air-conditioning kept the place cool. I could glimpse at least ten employees, so why had they closed the door?

Team Leader Choi answered calmly.

“We have to be open. There’s a customer.”

“You just said you were closed.”

[393] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

“That’s up to the owner, isn’t it?”

“Uh… Team Leader, I’m asking just to be sure.”

“You don’t need to ask. This café is mine.”

Right. I’d figured as much.

Thinking back, the café had also been empty except for the two of us the last time we met.

I keep digging, and the hole never ends.

I said in amazement, “Team Leader, you have a lot of money.”

“I have enough that I don’t need to worry about running short. That’s why I can put a contract like this in front of you.”

Team Leader Choi smiled gently and handed me a folder.

“Now, shall we talk business?”

There was no reason to hesitate any longer. I nodded firmly.

“Let’s.”

An hour later, just as I finished adding my final signature, the System alert rang out.

Ding.

Chapter 76

Ding.

This counts as an achievement too?

Whenever a System message like this appeared, I felt like I had become some kind of hero. An achievement, huh? That was quite an impressive way to package joining a Guild just to make money.

Well, I'm not complaining.

Ten points was a pretty sweet reward on its own, but after hearing what Team Leader Choi said next, I had to keep fighting the grin that threatened to spread across my face.

"The signing bonus will be processed by the end of today. As for your housing and other matters…"

A 500 million won[394] signing bonus, a fixed monthly salary of 50 million won,[395] and a seventy-percent settlement share.

A house and a car provided by the Guild, along with dozens of other benefits.

I had already gone over everything in the contract several times, but hearing it laid out like this made it all feel new again.

I've really made it.

Barely three months ago, I couldn't have imagined my life turning out like this.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi in Murim, and a Hunter in the real world who casually earned hundreds of millions of won[396] a year.

"Team Leader."

"As for equipment rentals, you can use anything you want apart from my collection… Yes?"

"Could you slap me once? If this is a dream, I'd like to wake up quickly."

The moment I finished speaking, my vision flashed.

Wham!

Wham? Not *smack*?

---

[394] 500 million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[395] 50 million won is about $36,000 or €32,000.

[396] Hundreds of millions of won means roughly 100–900 million won, or about $71,000–$640,000 or €65,000–€580,000.

I rubbed my stinging jaw and muttered, “You really don’t hold back.”

“I have trouble refusing a request.”

“I don’t think I told you to use your fist.”

“You didn’t tell me not to, either.”

“…”

Without my newly acquired **Toughness** stat, I might have gone sprawling in a most undignified fashion.

Right. This guy was a B-rank Hunter.

The punch he had thrown without even taking a stance had landed squarely on my jaw. The power, the point of impact—both perfect.

“Still, don’t people usually slap you?”

“There are exceptions. So, are you feeling more awake now?”

“…Wide awake.”

“Good. It’s better for making a first impression if you meet them while you’re in your right mind.”

His out-of-nowhere remark made me look at him in confusion.

“First impression? Who are we meeting?”

“Who do you think?”

Team Leader Choi continued with a smile.

“The other Guild members.”

“Ah.”

Only then did I remember something I had completely forgotten.

A Guild needed at least three people to be established.

“Shall we get going, then?”

Team Leader Choi pointed out the window. A sleek black limousine was gliding into the parking lot in front of the café.

“Congratulations.”

That deep, dignified voice, the sort that belonged in a coffee commercial, belonged to Butler Kim. Even in the sweltering summer heat, he wore a suit as he expertly drove the limousine.

“Oh, yes. Thank you.”

For some reason, I found it hard to speak naturally around this man. Was it because the only butlers I had ever seen were in dramas?

No. If that were the reason, Team Leader Choi would be even worse.

After giving it some thought, I decided it was Butler Kim's distinctive air. The unfamiliarity of riding in a limousine for the first time might have had something to do with it too.

A limousine.

The interior was spacious and stocked with all sorts of things. For example, the small refrigerator Team Leader Choi had just opened.

"Would you like something to drink?"

"Sure."

I happened to be thirsty.

"Water? Alcohol?"

"You have alcohol?"

Team Leader Choi nodded.

"Of course. Anything you want."

"Then I'll have soju and beer. Half and half."

"…I'll give you water."

The bottle of water Team Leader Choi handed me didn't have even the most ordinary brand name on it.

He told me it had been brought in from somewhere in the Himalayas, and I clicked my tongue inwardly.

That must cost a ridiculous amount.

What a fucking waste of money. Still, when I took a sip, it was refreshingly cold.

Gulp.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have consumed Essence of the Himalayas.
Your Intelligence increases by 1 for one hour.

…So this was why they blew all that fucking money. Well, this was how wealth got redistributed and the economy stayed active. Right.

The limousine came to a stop while I was wondering whether I should take a few bottles with me.

Butler Kim spoke in his characteristic deep voice.

"We've arrived."

The moment I stepped out, my jaw dropped at the sight before me.

A skyscraper towered into the sky. Its exterior gleamed even without direct sunlight, as if it had undergone some kind of magical treatment, and guards in formal uniforms stood waiting at the entrance.

“Wow. Woooow.”

As I continued to marvel at the sight, Team Leader Choi approached me.

“Impressive, isn’t it? It wouldn’t be an exaggeration to say that all the branches of Korea’s top one hundred Guilds are gathered here. There are even branches of foreign mega-Guilds whose names you know just from hearing them.”

I answered without taking my eyes off the building.

“Land must be insanely expensive here.”

“It is. You could call this the center of Gate activity around Bucheon.”

“Like Gangnam in the old days?”

“Neither of us lived through that era, but… from what I understand, this place is at least as expensive, if not more so.”

The value of land had been turned on its head long ago.

Though it had happened before I was born, middle-aged Hunters who had lived through the pre-Great Cataclysm era sometimes became nostalgic and went on about what things had been like back then.

“Back then, if you owned even one house in Gangnam, people said you were born with a gold spoon in your mouth.”

“People used to joke that Bundang was above heaven. That’s how valuable the land there was.”

“It was that expensive?”

“Expensive enough to make you puke. At least until the monsters invaded.”

I knew what happened after that. In the early days of the Great Cataclysm, well-developed metropolitan areas and densely populated regions were the first targets of the monster armies, and humanity had been helpless against them.

Present-day Gangnam and Bundang had both been destroyed once and rebuilt. After the Great Cataclysm, true prime real estate fell into two categories.

Safe zones and Gate-dense areas.

Safe zones, where the chance of a Gate appearing was close to zero, were the best places for ordinary people to live. Gate-dense areas, meanwhile, offered ideal conditions for Hunter Guilds to establish themselves.

Like a snack bar in front of an elementary school.

There were around a hundred Gates in Bucheon. Many were low-level, but by sheer number, Bucheon still ranked among the ten most Gate-dense areas in all of Korea.

And this was the center of it.

I could tell just by looking at the skyscrapers packed around us. This was a neighborhood where your average small or mid-sized Guild couldn’t even set foot.

Just how rich is this guy?

I was staring at Team Leader Choi in awe when he spoke.

“Let’s work hard and move somewhere like that, too.”

“I’ll devote my loyalty to you… Huh?”

“Pardon?”

“No, what?”

“What’s wrong?”

Damn it, why do you think? Are you asking because you don’t know?

I barely swallowed the words that had risen to my throat before managing to speak.

“You said we’d arrived?”

“Yes, we have.”

I whipped my head toward Butler Kim.

“Butler Kim, is this the place?”

“It is.”

Butler Kim nodded without hesitation, then added, “However, I believe you’re looking in the wrong direction.”

“The wrong direction?”

“Yes. If you turn your head a little to the right from where you’re standing, you should see it.”

I turned as instructed. After a brief silence, I asked, “What is that run-down building?”

Standing alone amid the luxurious skyscrapers, it looked especially small and dilapidated.

Butler Kim kindly explained.

“Strictly speaking, it’s a supermarket.”

“More precisely, it looks like a corner store.”

I narrowed my eyes and glared at the collapsing store. The yellowed sign read:

Sooni’s Super

“Who’s Sooni? What a tacky name.”

“She’s an old woman who’s lived here for seventy years.”

“Now that I think about it, it’s quite elegant. Sounds like a name that promises a long life.”

“She passed away two months ago.”

“Ah.”

Why is this happening to me?

“She was incredibly stubborn, so during the redevelopment of the Gate-dense area, she refused no matter how much money they offered. By then, the other Guilds had already established themselves… In the end, we purchased the property from her surviving family.”

"So that Sooni's Super is our Guild house?"

"Precisely."

I stared at the half-collapsed Sooni's Super with mixed feelings.

A Guild house was the face of a Guild. Its signboard. No matter how expensive the land in this neighborhood was, they had really chosen a place like that…

No, wait. For a newly established Guild, this is incredible.

It was only that my expectations had been too high. In an industry crawling with scams, Team Leader Choi had shown me enough sincerity that I could trust him and follow his lead.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes, Taekyung?"

I grabbed his hand.

"I'll work really hard. I don't care whether our Guild house is Sooni's Super or Sooni's Building."

Team Leader Choi answered with an awkward expression.

"I'm glad you understand."

"You know what they say. Though the beginning is humble, its end will be magnificent!"

"It's already fairly magnificent. Butler Kim, how much did it cost to purchase that lot?"

Butler Kim answered, "A little over two billion won[397] per pyeong.[398]"

"…Two billion won[399] per pyeong?[400]"

"Yes."

After a brief silence, I spoke.

"I believe the beginning is magnificent, but the end will be even more magnificent."

"…"

"…"

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim's gazes pierced me like arrows. Just as they stared at me with expressions that seemed to ask, *What kind of asshole is this?* a sound rang out.

Screeeech. Crash!

Sooni's Super

The sign, whose decades-old lettering had been neatly written in Hancom Batang,[401] slammed into the ground.

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[397] Two billion won is about $1.4 million or €1.3 million.

[398] A pyeong is a Korean unit of area equal to 3.31 m^2, or 35.6 ft^2.

[399] Two billion won is about $1.4 million or €1.3 million.

[400] A pyeong is a Korean unit of area equal to 3.31 m^2, or 35.6 ft^2.

[401] Hancom Batang is a Korean serif typeface distributed with Hancom's word-processing software.

"…It'll look fine once we remodel."

Team Leader Choi muttered in a tiny voice. Then the store door opened, and someone stepped out.

"Oh dear, it fell again."

Grumbling, the monstrously strong man lifted the fallen sign with one hand. At the appearance of this completely unexpected person, my mouth fell open.

"Uncle Kkeokjeong?"

The good-natured, middle-aged E-rank Hunter Im Kkeokjeong spotted us and waved with a bright smile.

"Hey, Taekyung!"

What the hell? How did this happen?

While I stood there dumbfounded, Im Kkeokjeong approached and patted me on the shoulder.

"You little punk. Been doing well? I heard you made C-rank."

"No, why are you here?"

"Hahaha! Why am I here? Is there something wrong with a Guild member being at the Guild house?"

After letting out a hearty laugh, he continued.

"I was stuck lying in the hospital when Team Leader Choi suddenly came to see me and asked if I wanted to join the Guild. I said yes without a second thought."

Team Leader Choi, who had been looking sadly at the fallen sign, added, "He seemed like someone I could trust."

"That young man knows what loyalty means. Mr. Kim over there doesn't say much, but he's a really good man. And Miss Song goes without saying."

"No, wait. Hold on."

What was going on here?

I asked as calmly as I could, "You joined recently?"

"Yeah."

Team Leader Choi cut in again.

"He seemed like someone I could trust."

"That young man knows what loyalty means. Mr. Kim over there doesn't say much, but…"

"I heard that part already. What about the others?"

"Huh?"

"Where are the other Guild members? Surely these four aren't everyone."

"Of course not."

Im Kkeokjeong answered firmly, then added, "Miss Song went grocery shopping. She said she'd throw you a welcome party."

“Miss Song? Don’t tell me she’s the last one.”

“Yeah. Including Miss Song, there are five of us. She left over an hour ago, so she should be back soon.”

I couldn’t hear anything after that.

Five people.

Is this a dream?

Im Kkeokjeong’s booming voice snapped me out of my daze as I stared blankly at the collapsing Sooni’s Super.

“Oh, there she is. Miss Song! Over here, over here! The newbie’s here!”

I followed his gaze and turned my head.

The final Guild member of the ultra-tiny Guild, and one of its founding members.

She was there.

Chapter 77

When two men sit around drinking, all kinds of topics are bound to come spilling out. Money, people, the future…

Of all those topics, Jinho hyung's[402] favorite was women.

Whenever he got drunk, he became the saddest man in the world and reminisced about his first love.

"I first met her when I was a high school sophomore."

"This guy's drunk again."

"It was March, the start of a new school year, and the flowers were in full bloom. She opened the classroom door and walked in, and then…"

"You must've been dazzled. The bells of heaven must've started ringing in your ears—ding, ding, ding?"

"Huh? How did you know?"

"Because I've heard this story more than a hundred times. The bells of heaven, my ass. Go write a novel."

"That's because you don't understand love, you punk. Then again, what would a lifelong single know?"

"It's not that I couldn't date. I chose not to."

"You lifelong-single bastards always say that. Is there some kind of guidebook? You've never even liked anyone, have you?"

"…I-I think I have."

"Oh, forget it. What good is telling you a hundred or a thousand times? You have to experience it yourself to understand. Pour me another drink."

The reason I suddenly remembered that drinking session from a few months ago was simple.

Hyung was right.

Ding—ding—

I could hear them. The bells.

Miss Song.

She had a slender figure and a tiny face. An angel with grocery bags dangling from both hands spotted me and stopped short.

"Who are you?"

[402] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or older male friend. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

Her captivating yet refreshing voice made my mind go blank, while her delicate, doll-like features set my heart pounding.

My God.

I swallowed hard. It felt as though I had spent the past twenty-seven years as a lifelong single just for this day.

A simulation was already running in my head.

We'll live in a country house with a yard. Two children and one cat. Perfect.

The dating cells that had never budged, even while I circulated my qi, were springing to life.

I opened my mouth, trying to make my voice as low as possible. Jinho hyung, a self-proclaimed master of romance, had repeatedly stressed that I should use a deep, resonant voice with a woman I liked.

"I'm…"

"This is Jin Taekyung. You've heard about him too, right, Miss Song? You know, the one I told you about last time. I said my beloved little brother had undergone reawakening as a C-rank Hunter."

"Oh, you're that person? You're younger than I expected."

"…"

I gently stepped on Im Kkeokjeong's foot for cutting in out of nowhere, then opened my mouth again.

"Yes. I'm the very…"

"Why did you buy so much? We have a restaurant reserved."

"It's expensive and the portions are tiny. Why go there? We can just grill some meat inside."

"…"

Team Leader Choi. I'm going to kill you with my own hands. I definitely will.

I glared at the meddlers one after another. Butler Kim had been about to say something, but under my murderous stare, he quietly closed his mouth.

This is my only chance.

The timing was perfect. No one was interrupting, and Miss Song was looking right at me. I spoke in an attractive, deep voice.

"Hello. My name is Jin Taekyung. I'm twenty-seven years old and recently became a C-rank Hunter. My birthday is April 22. I'm a Taurus, and my blood type is RH-positive, type A. My hobbies are reading and film criticism. I hope we get along."

"…"

"…"

"…"

In the still silence, no one said a word. At last, her red lips parted.

"Oh, yes."

Miss Song stared straight at me with her doe-like eyes. She looked completely spellbound by my cavernous voice. And I had even highlighted my intellectual side by mentioning reading and film criticism. This was a hundred-percent success.

Thank you, Jinho hyung. If this works out, drinks are on me.

Just as I was cheering inside, Team Leader Choi cut in with a stammer.

“W-Why don’t we take our time and talk over a meal? Song-i must be tired from grocery shopping.”

My anger at being interrupted again vanished without a trace the moment I heard her name.

“Song-i?”

“Song Song. My name is Song Song.”

Miss Song—or rather, Song-i—answered calmly before slipping inside the store. I stood there blankly, repeating her name to myself.

“Song Song…”

My God, even her name is beautiful. Charming. Dazzling.

She was my type from head to toe. I was half out of my mind at the thought that I had met my destined partner when Team Leader Choi’s voice snapped me out of it.

“Taekyung.”

“Yes, yes?”

“Um… Never mind. Take your time coming in.”

Team Leader Choi let out a deep sigh and turned away. *What was wrong with him?*

“Did I do something wrong?”

At my question, Butler Kim, who had been following Team Leader Choi, stopped short.

“Um… Stay strong.”

Once the two of them left, only Im Kkeokjeong and I remained.

“Hyung-nim. Did I make some kind of mistake?”

“A mistake? No. You committed a crime.”

“A crime?”

“Yes. A crime that can never be forgiven.”

“Gasp.”

Had I really done something wrong? Just as my heart sank, Im Kkeokjeong continued with a solemn expression.

“The crime of stealing a woman’s heart.”

“…!”

“You little punk. Even I almost fell for you. Did you see Miss Song’s expression? She was completely smitten. It’s over. You won!”

“R-Really?”

“Congratulations, Taekyung! Let’s eat noodles!”[403]

“Hyung-nim!”

I couldn’t contain my emotion and threw myself into Im Kkeokjeong’s arms. He laughed heartily and patted me on the back.

“How many kids are you going to have? What? Two? Don’t stop there—make it three! Hahahaha!”

Inside the store.

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim, who had been pressed right up against the door, turned to face each other.

“What do you think, Butler Kim?”

“I can only admire the Young Master’s wise decision to block out the sound with a magic Item.”

“Right?”

“Precisely.”

As if they had planned it, the two men glanced over their shoulders. Song Song was bustling around, preparing the meal.

“If Song-i had heard that conversation just now…”

“Even if Miss Song quit the Guild on the spot, we would have to pay the penalty.”

“Where did he learn lines like that? Butler Kim, when you were younger, did you perhaps…?”

Butler Kim’s expression turned stern.

“Young Master, that remark was highly unpleasant to hear. Lines like that did not exist even before the Great Cataclysm.”

“Taekyung has been single his entire life, right?”

“If he isn’t, then as of today I’m no longer Butler Kim. I’m Butler Park.”

“Hunter Im seems to have problems too.”

“I hate to say this, but I wanted to put a muzzle on him.”

“Hunter Im is unmarried, right?”

“Unfortunately, he’s married. He even has two children.”

“How on earth…?”

“I wonder the same thing.”

The Guild’s future was bleak.

Just as the two men shook their heads with gloomy expressions, a voice came from behind them.

“Excuse me.”

[403] In Korea, “eating noodles” can refer to celebrating someone’s wedding.

Song Song stood there in an apron, one hand on her hip as she looked at the two men.

“What are you two whispering about? You haven’t lifted a finger to help while I’ve been preparing everything.”

“Oh, Miss Song. It’s just…”

“We’ll clean up after the meal.”

“Forget it. The food’s ready, so come and eat. And call Mr. Im and…”

Song Song continued with a sigh.

“That… Taurus, too.”

In front of the grill, which had been heated to just the right temperature, I opened my mouth with a solemn expression.

“Miss Song.”

Song Song stopped just as she picked up the tongs and scissors.

“Yes?”

“Give them to me. I’ll grill the meat.”

“It’s fine. You can help clean up afterward.”

“My hobby is grilling meat, and my specialty is cutting it.”

“…I thought your hobbies were reading and film criticism?”

“That was only the tip of the iceberg.”

I nudged Im Kkeokjeong’s foot under the table, and he immediately provided backup.

“You wouldn’t know this, Miss Song, but this guy can grill meat like nobody’s business. One time, he was working five grills at once, just—huh? And when you bite into it, the juices flood your mouth. Fireworks start going off in your head!”

I added one more point in a dignified tone.

“I’m a Taurus.”

“That’s right! A Taurus man grills meat well, and he’s pure-hearted, honest, and so steadfast…”

Crack.

Team Leader Choi set down the broken wooden chopsticks and muttered, “I’m sorry. I couldn’t control my strength.”

“Here.”

As if she had been waiting for that moment, Song Song handed him a fresh pair of chopsticks. My heart sank.

I hated to admit it, but the beautiful woman and the handsome man looked perfect together.

No way. It can't be.

I tried to deny it, but my heart felt heavy.

With a gloomy expression, I placed the meat on the grill.

Sizzle.

What kind of relationship did Song Song have with Team Leader Choi?

Sizzle.

It was obvious they had known each other for a long time. She wouldn't be a founding member of the Guild otherwise.

Sizzle.

Come to think of it, that bastard Team Leader Choi was suspicious. He'd been interrupting our conversation from the start. And why had he snapped a perfectly good pair of chopsticks and ruined the mood?

Sizzle.

A B-rank Hunter claiming he couldn't control his strength? What kind of bullshit excuse was that? Was he showing off how strong he was in front of Song Song? I could tie metal chopsticks into a knot too…

"Excuse me."

I looked up with a start. Eyes as clear as a lake were staring straight at me.

"It's burning."

"Yes, yes?"

"The meat. It's burning."

"Gasp!"

Sizzle-sizzle-sizzle.

I hurriedly flipped the meat, but it was already too late.

"I'll do it."

"No. I will."

"Come to think of it, since you're here for the first time today, it's only right that I grill the meat and serve you."

My God. She wasn't just an angel on the outside.

Oh, Miss Song. You're an ethics textbook.[404]

I fell for her nature, gentle as silk, all over again.

Slice. Slice.

Sizzle.

After taking the tongs from me, she grilled and cut the meat with practiced skill.

I watched her in a daze.

She even looks beautiful grilling meat.

[404] "Ethics textbook" is a Korean wordplay on a phrase meaning "what on earth are you?"

Her hair was loosely twisted into a bun, and her slender, pale hands moved busily. Every movement seemed to shine.

"Hmm."

How much time had passed? She had been watching the meat carefully when she spoke.

"It's done. Could you hand me a plate?"

"Yes, ma'am."

She neatly placed the fully cooked meat into a disposable container. I had noticed it earlier, but this was clearly not something she had done only once or twice.

"You must've done this a lot."

"Yes."

"Did you work part-time at a barbecue restaurant?"

"Yes."

"Wow. For how long?"

"Two years."

"Wow, when?"

"When I was in high school."

"Huh. Not many kids had part-time jobs back then."

"Oh, yes."

What am I going to do? Even her resourcefulness is exactly my type.

Her answers seemed strangely short, but that had to be my imagination. I kept showering her with enthusiastic little responses to keep the conversation going.

The conversation itself is going smoothly.

Jinho hyung had said that if you wanted someone to like you, you had to start by finding common ground. I launched into my story with enthusiasm.

"We're pretty similar. I used to work two or even three shifts in a day. One day, after I finished work and came home…"

"Oh, yes. But, um…"

"Yes?"

"You seem a little close. The grill is still hot…"

Without realizing it, I had leaned my entire body toward Song Song.

"It's fine. I'll just get a little burned. Hahaha!"

"You should still be careful."

"I'm really fine. You don't have to worry."

"…"

Song Song's expression seemed strangely dark.

Could it be…?

Is she worried I might get hurt?

I was stunned. She was thinking about me this much even though we had only met today.

And then I knew for certain. She was interested in me, too.

Jinho hyung's voice reached me from somewhere, like an auditory hallucination.

"Do you know what the most important virtue is when it comes to becoming a couple? Courage."

"Taekyung, remember this. A man with courage wins the beauty."

Hyung, I think I finally understand. And thank you.

That's right. Let's be brave.

I stared at her, my heart trembling. What I was about to say was something I had never once said in all twenty-seven years of my life.

"Miss Song. Starting today, you and I are on day one…"[405]

At that moment, Team Leader Choi shot to his feet and shouted.

"Day one! Today is Hunter Jin Taekyung's first day as a member of our Guild family! Butler Kim?"

"Yes, Young Master! The soju[406] is ready!"

The usually unhurried Butler Kim filled the shot glasses at lightning speed.

Glug-glug-glug!

Not a gentle trickle—it was pouring full blast.

Half of it spilled, and the other half was poured in with brute force. The sight left me speechless, but there was something I absolutely had to say.

"Miss Song. Let me say it again. You and I…"

Team Leader Choi raised his glass high.

"To our Guild!"

"Miss Song. Ignore them and listen to me."

Song Song answered.

"To our Guild!"

"…"

She didn't hear me, right? Yeah. She couldn't have heard me.

[405] "Day one" refers to the first day of a romantic relationship.

[406] *Soju* is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

Chapter 78

Hunters are all hard drinkers.

Even an F-rank Hunter—the lowest classification—has physical abilities and a metabolism far beyond those of an ordinary person.

There's a reason people say some Hunters don't drink, but no Hunter can't drink.

"Hic. One more glass."

Well, there was one here.

Miss Song-i's eyes were already half-glazed as she shook her empty glass furiously.

"One more glaaass!"

She's pretty even when she's drunk… No, that's not the point. Isn't this getting a little dangerous?

I looked at Miss Song-i with concern.

She must've drunk too fast.

The moment the drinking party had begun in earnest, she had chugged an entire bottle of soju[407] straight from the bottle and had been like this ever since. Every now and then, she slurred incomprehensible things about someone having no damn tact and rotten luck clinging like a curse.

Is something bad going on?

While Im Kkeokjeong was filling her glass, I leaned toward Team Leader Choi and whispered.

"Team Leader. Did something happen to Miss Song-i?"

Team Leader Choi answered with an awkward expression.

"…Something did happen."

"I knew it."

"Very recently, too."

"Oh. Ah."

Miss Song's misfortune was my misfortune. Just sitting there and watching her was breaking my heart.

"Whew. I hope things work out for her."

"…"

"…"

Team Leader Choi, and even Butler Kim, who was sitting beside him, stared at me with strange expressions.

This was starting to feel weird.

"What?"

"Nothing."

[407] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink commonly served with meals.

"People can be like that when they're young."

It was an oddly lukewarm answer, but that wasn't important right now.

Crack.

"Drink! Today, we drink ourselves to death!"

Miss Song had opened her third bottle of soju[408] and was going wild.

"Ha-ha-ha! This is why I like Miss Song so much!"

Like a fish in water—no, like a bandit who'd found booze—Im Kkeokjeong egged her on from beside her.

"Shouldn't we stop her?"

"Ah, Miss Song-i?"

"Yes."

Team Leader Choi shrugged.

"It's fine. It's not like I've only known her for a day or two. That's just how Miss Song gets when she drinks."

"Even so… No, wait a second."

I fixed Team Leader Choi with a penetrating stare.

He'd seemed suspicious for a while, and now I'd finally caught him.

"How do you know what Miss Song is like when she drinks?"

"Because I've drunk with her."

"…"

Was this bastard making fun of me? Did he think I was asking because I couldn't figure that out?

"That's not what I mean."

"Then what do you mean?"

"I mean…"

Now that he'd put it that way, I had nothing to say. When I thought about it, who was I to question the relationship between them?

Just as I found myself at a loss for words, Team Leader Choi suddenly spoke.

"You've heard of Ares, right?"

"Of course."

Ares, the god of war.

The name of a god from ancient Greek and Roman mythology. These days, though, it was famous for something else.

"Who in Korea doesn't know the Ares Guild?"

The pride and joy of Korea's Hunters.

[408] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink commonly served with meals.

Hundreds of Guilds existed in Korea, but only one stood at the top: the Ares Guild. From the early days of the Great Cataclysm to the present, their achievements had been too numerous to count.

They're legends. Plain and simple.

They appeared in educational comics, educational animations, movies, novels, and all kinds of other media. They had even made it into textbooks.

The Ares Guild held a position in Korea comparable to a living King Sejong[409] or an active Admiral Yi Sun-sin.[410] No, perhaps even higher.

They're famous all over the world, after all.

If you asked most foreigners, "Do you know King Sejong? King-God-General Yi Sun-sin?" they'd probably think, *What the hell is this Asian bastard talking about?* But the Ares Guild was different.

"Do you know Ares?"

"Oh, yes!"

Even a tough-as-nails Texas grandpa would slap his twin pistols and know what you meant. That was the accepted academic consensus.

"Why are you asking about the Ares Guild?"

Team Leader Choi swallowed a mouthful of beer before answering.

"Because I used to be there."

"Oh. I see… Huh?"

What had I just heard?

I blinked for a while before finally speaking.

"You used to belong to the Ares Guild?"

"I was a Team Leader. Though I was pretty far down the ladder."

The Ares Guild had high standards. They selected only the best and trained them to become even better. Team Leader Choi had called himself low-ranking, but the fact that he'd made Team Leader there was already incredible.

Though right now, he just looked like a lunatic to me.

"Then why did you leave?"

Money, honor, status.

It was the best job any Hunter—or any man—could dream of. And he had kicked it all away and left!

"Were you ostracized at work or something?"

Team Leader Choi thought about it for a moment before answering.

---

[409] King Sejong was a fifteenth-century Korean ruler best known for overseeing the creation of the Korean alphabet.

[410] Admiral Yi Sun-sin was a Korean naval commander celebrated for defending Korea during the Japanese invasions of the late sixteenth century.

“That might have been the case. Miss Song was the only person who treated me normally.”

“…Then was Miss Song in the Ares Guild too?”

“She was on my team. I found out about her drinking habits during team dinners.”

I swallowed hard.

These people are total elites.

My gaze moved back and forth between Team Leader Choi, who was sipping his beer, and Miss Song, who was drinking straight from the bottle, before stopping on one person.

“Could it be that Butler Kim also…?”

“Me?”

Butler Kim smiled kindly and waved a hand.

“I retired a long time ago. Ha-ha-ha.”

“What?”

So he was a former Hunter.

Suddenly, I remembered the sense of incongruity I had always felt whenever I dealt with Butler Kim. I had also never once tried to assess him with my Qi Sense.

Who is this man, really?

Just as I was about to raise my Qi Sense, Im Kkeokjeong, who had been enthusiastically inhaling meat and liquor whether or not we were talking, spoke up.

“Oh, the burner went out. Miss Song, do we have another gas canister?”

“Hic. That was the last one.”

“Aw, we can’t let the momentum die. Should we just eat it?”

Im Kkeokjeong grumbled as he flipped a piece of meat that was still mostly raw. Butler Kim smiled gently at him.

“That won’t do.”

The next moment, two things happened at once.

Snap!

Butler Kim snapped his fingers.

Fwoosh!

A wave of scorching heat burst forth. Blue flames surged precisely up over the grill, heating the plate and cooking the meat in an instant before vanishing.

“This is…”

Im Kkeokjeong and I shouted at the same time.

“A mage!”

“It’s cooked incredibly well!”

“…”

"What? Taekyung, hurry up and eat."

Forget it, old man.

I shook my head back and forth.

More importantly, who would've guessed Butler Kim was a mage? No wonder something about him had always felt strange.

"You really had me fooled."

Butler Kim picked up a well-cooked piece of meat.

"I had no intention of fooling you. As I told you, I'm already a retired has-been."

Has-been, my ass.

If Butler Kim was a has-been, half the mages still active today ought to bow their damn heads.

At least B-rank.

He could summon flames with a single snap of his fingers and control them precisely enough to cook the meat just right without burning or undercooking it. Judging from the circumstances, he had probably belonged to the Ares Guild as well before retiring.

If he had been active during the Great Cataclysm, too…

…This guy's a big shot.

On top of that, he was an incredibly senior one.

I asked cautiously, "Um, which Hunter training center did you graduate from?"

"Nonsan.[411] What about you, Mr. Taekyung?"

"Gasp. Me too. The 28th Regiment, 1st Battalion."

"Really? What a coincidence. I was in the 28th Regiment, 1st Battalion too. Which company were you in?"

"Second Company."

"Then perhaps it isn't a coincidence but fate. Ha-ha."

There was nothing more to discuss. I rose from my seat and bowed deeply at the waist.

"Nice to meet you, Senior."

There's a saying in Korea about school ties, regional ties, and blood ties.[412] Hunters were no different.

The chance of awakening was 0.1 percent—one in a thousand. With odds that slim, it was rare for anyone you knew from ordinary life to awaken. The Hunter training center might not seem like much, but it was where a Hunter's network began.

"You don't have to go this far. Please, sit down."

---

[411] Nonsan is home to Korea's main Army recruit training center.

[412] School ties, regional ties, and blood ties are traditionally regarded in Korea as major sources of social connections and influence.

“You can speak casually with me.”

“I don’t really stand on ceremony…”

Just as Butler Kim and I were creating a warm atmosphere between Senior and junior, Team Leader Choi, who had been watching quietly, suddenly cut in.

“Butler Kim. Why don’t you do as Mr. Jin Taekyung says?”

What an ill-mannered bastard. How dare he tell such a distinguished Senior what to do…

Hmm. I guess he can.

Come to think of it, Team Leader Choi was the bigger shot. He employed a former Ares Guild mage as his butler.

What kind of family does he come from?

Was his grandfather the President and his father the prime minister?

As my curiosity continued to grow, Team Leader Choi went on.

“I think it’s time we sorted out everyone’s forms of address. You’re the face of our Guild, after all. We can’t keep calling you Butler Kim or Uncle forever, can we?”

Butler Kim considered it for a moment before answering.

“I’ll follow the Young Master’s wishes.”

Team Leader Choi nodded and swept a stern gaze over everyone present.

“Then from now on, we’ll all address Butler Kim as Guild Master. No objections, correct?”

Im Kkeokjeong and Miss Song answered.

“Man, this meat is incredible. Is it because it was grilled with Magic?”

“The booze is going in. Booze! Down it goes, down it goes!”

“…”

Team Leader Choi gazed at the two of them with regret before turning his eyes toward me. I had raised one arm conspicuously.

“What does that mean?”

“I have a question.”

At least this guy is a little better.

Team Leader Choi spoke with an expression that seemed to say as much.

“Go ahead.”

“Wasn’t Team Leader Choi the Guild Master?”

“…”

Looking as if he had been betrayed, Team Leader Choi pulled something from inside his coat and handed it to me. I took it and examined it.

It was a business card.

“I have this.”

“What does it say?”

“Choi Minwoo, Team Leader of Team 1, Peace Guild.”

“Yes. I’m the Team Leader.”

“Oh.”

“Butler Kim is the Guild Master. I’m the Team Leader. The other three are team members. Do you understand now?”

I didn’t know whether Butler Kim was a boss in name only or a public figurehead, but I nodded anyway.

If I didn’t, Team Leader Choi looked like he might cry.

“Did everyone else understand?”

At Team Leader Choi’s question, Im Kkeokjeong and Miss Song answered.

“Wow, even the liquor tastes amazing. Is it because we’ve got magically grilled meat to go with it?”

“How long are you going to make me do the shoulder dance? It’s dislocated! Dislocated! Dislocated!”

“…”

Hey, are you crying?

Chapter 79

I woke with a dull headache and looked around. I was in an unfamiliar place—a spacious, clean hotel room.

Only then did the memories of last night gradually come back to me.

Right. We came to a hotel for the second round and had a champagne party.

Good God. A champagne party at a hotel.

Put that way, I felt like I'd become the third-generation heir to some chaebol[413] family. Then again, Team Leader Choi might actually be one.

"Khrrr-heeeurk. Khrrp!"

"…"

That man really was a bandit.

What kind of snoring sounded like someone shouting? Jinho hyung[414] was a champion snorer himself, but next to this guy, he might as well have been on mute.

If I were the hotel manager, I would've kicked him out long ago—

Knock, knock.

"Who is it?"

For a moment, I thought a hotel employee had come to inform us that we were being thrown out. But no. A clear, bright voice came from the other side of the door.

"It's me. Song Song."

Wait. Who?

"J-just a moment!"

I dashed to the door at the speed of light. Before opening it, I made sure to spray on some of the perfume provided in the room and straighten my clothes.

Click.

Miss Song-i's clear, lake-like eyes gazed steadily at me, setting my heart pounding. I barely managed to squeeze out a greeting in a trembling voice.

"G-good morning. Did you sleep well?"

"No. The snoring kept waking me up."

"Oh."

Not a good start. I blamed Im Kkeokjeong, who was still snoring ferociously, and quickly changed the subject.

"But what brings you here?"

"It's time for breakfast."

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[413] A chaebol is a large, family-controlled South Korean business conglomerate.

[414] Hyung is a term a man uses for an older brother or older male friend. Hyung-nim is a more deferential form.

"…Breakfast?"

Miss Song looked at me as if she couldn't see what the problem was.

"Yes. Why?"

Why? Because I'm happy.

Who would've thought I'd live to see the day I had breakfast alone with a woman? And not just any woman—one who was exactly my type. I could almost feel my eyes welling up.

At last, an oasis has appeared in my desert of a life.

I wouldn't have minded eating combat rations for breakfast as long as I was eating them with her. I answered with determination.

"I'll get ready right now."

"Then could you wake Uncle Kkeokjeong first?"

"…Why Kkeokjeong Hyung-nim?[415]"

"Didn't you check the chat?"

Miss Song held out her smartphone.

The Guild group chat we had created last night was open on the screen.

> **Peace Guild**
> **Team Leader Choi:** Is everyone awake?
> **Butler Kim:** I'm up.
> **Song Song:** I'm up too.
> **Team Leader Choi:** What about the other two?
> **Song Song:** They're snoring.
> **Team Leader Choi:** …Wake them up and come to the restaurant on the first floor.

"…"

Damn it. And just when I was getting excited. Story of my life.

Leaving me there dejected, Miss Song turned away.

"Then I'll go down first."

I stared longingly at her retreating back as she walked away on light, graceful steps.

"Even her back is pretty."

"Khrrp, khrrr-heeeurk!"

"…"

Is this guy really not a former bandit?

[415] Hyung is a term a man uses for an older brother or older male friend. Hyung-nim is a more deferential form.

After barely managing to wake Im Kkeokjeong, I headed down to the first floor with him.

Team Leader Choi was sitting by the window. He waved when he saw us.

“I ordered ahead. Eat before it gets cold.”

Since it was a hotel breakfast, I had expected something like an absurdly tiny serving of pasta. Instead, a steaming bowl of haejangguk sat on the table.[416]

“Ah, now that’s Team Leader Choi!”

“You really know your stuff, Team Leader.”

I still had some of last night’s hangover left, but one bowl of haejangguk[417] seemed like it would make circulating my qi unnecessary.

Team Leader Choi shook his head at our reactions.

“Miss Song ordered it. I wanted pasta.”

“Miss Song did?”

“Yes.”

Judging by his dark expression, he must have really wanted that pasta.

Still, I never would’ve expected Miss Song to order hangover soup. Judging by her appearance, she looked like a pampered young lady from a wealthy family. But after what she had shown us yesterday, and now this, she had a surprisingly down-to-earth side.

Slurp.

“Ah, that hits the spot. What are you all doing? You should eat while the broth’s still hot.”

Watching Miss Song dig into her haejangguk[418] warmed a corner of my heart. Even the way she ate was delightful.

So this is what it means when simply looking at someone fills you up.

In a state where I could no longer tell whether the food was going into my nose or my mouth, the meal finally came to an end. While everyone except me sagged back in their seats, bloated with food, Team Leader Choi spoke.

“Now that we’ve eaten, shall we move somewhere else?”

What? Wasn’t this supposed to be the part where we went home and rested?

“Move where?”

Im Kkeokjeong cut in, patting his bulging belly.

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[416] Haejangguk, literally “hangover soup,” is a Korean soup traditionally eaten after drinking to help ease a hangover.

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[418] Haejangguk, literally “hangover soup,” is a Korean soup traditionally eaten after drinking to help ease a hangover.

“Where else? We’ve got to keep the party going from yesterday. How about makgeolli[419] today? I know a good place.”

“Oh, I really like makgeolli[420] too.”

Butler Kim, who had been quietly listening to us, smiled and continued.

“Unfortunately, I think we’d better save that for our next Guild dinner. We have something more important to take care of today.”

Butler Kim might have been the Guild Master, but someone else made the decisions.

With everyone’s eyes on him, Team Leader Choi opened his mouth.

“We’ve eaten, drunk, and rested. Now it’s time to work.”

It was the Peace Guild’s first raid.

The Great Cataclysm left humanity reeling in shock.

Gates appeared without warning one day, and unknown creatures came pouring out of them.

“W-what is that?”

“A monster! It’s a monster!”

People might have been less shocked if aliens with thin limbs and oversized heads had invaded instead. But these creatures hadn’t arrived in spaceships, nor did they fire guns.

“Skreeee!”

“Karuk! Krrruuuk!”

With their terrible stench and eyes gleaming with killing intent, the monsters tore humans apart like sheets of paper as they swept through cities and set them ablaze.

They were monsters that seemed as if they belonged in novels, movies, or myths.

The Minotaur was one of them…or so I had learned in history class.

“You know what a Minotaur is, right?”

Im Kkeokjeong answered proudly.

“Of course. I saw them in a Greek and Roman mythology comic when I was in elementary school. They were pretty cool—huge muscles and everything.”

“…What about you, Taekyung?”

“I’ve never even seen one.”

A Minotaur was among the stronger monsters in the B-rank category. It had been roughly five hundred light-years away from me, an eternal F-rank Hunter.

[419] Makgeolli is a traditional Korean rice wine with a milky appearance and a mildly sweet, tangy flavor.
[420] Makgeolli is a traditional Korean rice wine with a milky appearance and a mildly sweet, tangy flavor.

"That's all right. This is your chance to see one."

"…"

Is a Gate a zoo? Are we going there just to sightsee?

Team Leader Choi answered breezily, as if this had nothing to do with him, and handed me a tablet.

"Here."

"What is this?"

"It's a next-generation tablet powered by a C-rank Magic Gem. With its elegant design and outstanding performance, it's sold exclusively to a select number of VIPs…"

"Just give me the conclusion."

"I loaded some raid footage onto it. Watch."

He could've just said that from the start. Im Kkeokjeong and I put our heads together and watched the video stored on the tablet.

"All right, stay calm. Stay calm. Especially the tanks! Keep those shields up. If they break through, everyone here is dead. Of course, I'll kill you myself before that happens."

"Yes, sir!"

Around fifteen Hunters formed an orderly formation at the raid leader's command. Every one of them was visibly tense.

Four tanks, melee and ranged damage dealers. They've even got a mage and a healer.

Their teamwork seemed decent, and so did the team composition.

And then…

So that's a Minotaur.

A B-rank monster I had only ever seen in monster encyclopedias appeared on the screen.

"Moooooo!"

A cow's head on a human body. Seven half-human, half-beast Minotaurs advanced toward the intruders.

No—they charged.

"Mooooooo!"

Their bellowing echoed through the cave. Rock dust shook loose and fell in little showers as the battle began.

"Ranged! Fire!"

The raid leader screamed himself hoarse. At the same moment, around twenty mana-infused arrows struck the lead Minotaur in the head.

Fwish-fwish-fwish!

Focusing fire on one target instead of using a wide-area attack had been a good choice. Aiming precisely for its head had been especially effective.

No matter how strong a B-rank monster was, it couldn't reinforce its eyeballs.

The Minotaur clawed at its own face in agony. The finishing blow came from the companions following behind it.

Crunch!

A dark iron club smashed the cow's head apart.

And then—

Thud, thud, thud!

Huh.

They used the dead Minotaur's corpse as a shield and charged straight ahead. Arrows and magic rained down, but they only shredded the corpse. The Minotaurs hiding behind it were unharmed.

These bastards…

They knew how to use their heads. They were at least as intelligent as goblins and dozens of times stronger.

That made them all the more dangerous.

"Hold!"

"Urrrgh!"

At the team leader's shout, the tanks' veins bulged. Their shields, covered in hazy mana, blocked the iron clubs carrying tremendous force.

Wham! Wham! Wham!

A small shadow suddenly dropped out of the air between them. A stealth-type Hunter drove a black-painted dagger into another Minotaur's eye, then vanished.

"Moooo…"

B-rank monsters weren't invincible. With support from the other melee damage dealers, archers, and mage, two more Minotaurs fell in the blink of an eye.

But the crisis came quickly.

They're breaking through!

No sooner had the thought occurred to me than the wavering tank line collapsed.

Kra-koom!

"Graaagh!"

"Healer! Healer!"

Screams and roars filled the cave. Through the billowing dust, I could see the cow-headed monsters tearing through the formation and swinging their iron clubs.

"Moooooo!"

"Tanks, damage dealers! Ranged, don't hold back your mana—pour it all in! Ranged, open up some distance!"

Wham-wham-wham!

"Mooooooo!"

"Healeeeer!"

The video continued for about ten minutes before cutting off. The battle hadn't ended yet. The camera had simply been smashed by an iron club.

"Moooooooo!"

Bzzzt.

As the Minotaur's roar rang out, the screen filled with static and faded to black and white. Im Kkeokjeong swallowed hard.

"…This is no joke."

Of course it isn't, old man.

I handed the tablet back to Team Leader Choi and asked,

"What Guild was that?"

"It was footage of the Bucheon Terminal Guild's raid last week."

"…"

Whoever named that Guild had one hell of a sense for names.

Not that I had much room to talk as a member of the Peace Guild, but at least our name was better than Bucheon Terminal Guild.

"What was the result?"

"The Minotaurs were wiped out. Two Hunters died."

People dying during raids wasn't particularly rare. Being a Hunter meant repeatedly drawing close to death, then running away from it.

Even so, I couldn't help feeling heavy-hearted. It was a burden the survivors would have to carry for the rest of their lives.

Just as I did now.

"I see."

That was all I could manage. I pulled out my smartphone and searched for the incident. Several related articles appeared.

> **A Bucheon Guild: The Sacrifice Brought on by a Reckless Raid**
> On the sixteenth, C-rank Hunters identified as Mr. Lee and Mr. Park died in the B-rank Gate *The Minotaur's Labyrinth*. The Hunter Association authorities…

So the Hunters who died had been C-rank. That made sense. A small-to-medium Guild like that couldn't possibly have enough talent to fill all fifteen or so spots on a raid team with B-rank Hunters.

Then…

I quickly looked over the Guild members. The Qi Sense I had activated a moment earlier had already brought up their Level windows.

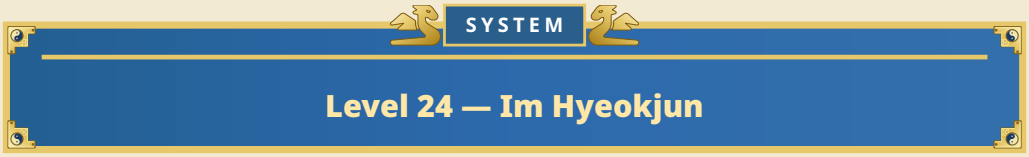
Ding. Ding. Ding.

The next moment, my eyes met Im Kkeokjeong's.

"What's wrong?"

"It's nothing."

I answered as casually as I could and turned away, but my thoughts were anything but casual.



This raid is dangerous.

Chapter 80

Gate Management Office.

A young man in gleaming armor scowled.

“So why isn’t it allowed?”

The public official in charge of the B-rank Gate *The Minotaur’s Labyrinth* looked troubled.

“I already told you. Because of the fatal accident last week…”

“You think I don’t know that? I’m asking why you’re being so uptight with someone you know.”

“It’s a safety-inspection period. If you’re short on personnel, I can’t exactly approve your entry.”

The official was at his wit’s end.

Any Gate where a fatal accident occurred was subjected to a week of safety inspections. The required number or level of personnel was raised to prevent another accident. But the young man in front of him refused to listen.

“I put in a little extra this time. Good enough?”

“What is this!”

The official jumped at the white envelope the young man thrust toward him and glanced around in alarm. A recent hire was staring at him with wide, round eyes.

“You—you can’t do this.”

“Can’t do what? You’ve been taking it just fine until now.”

“…”

“Being in charge of a Gate is supposed to have perks like this, right?”

At the young man’s blatant remark, the middle-aged official’s face flushed red. It wasn’t as if this was anything new, but what kind of disgrace was this in front of a new employee?

Still, the milk had already been spilled. His conscience grew thinner in proportion to the thickness of the white envelope.

“So… what’s your current team composition?”

“Ten, including me.”

“Ten?”

“Five B-ranks and five C-ranks. Why? Is there a problem?”

Of course there was. The Bucheon Terminal Guild, which had been involved in last week’s accident, had sent five B-rank Hunters and ten C-rank Hunters into the Gate. What happened to them had been plastered all over the front page of the local newspaper.

> **The Tragedy Brought on by a Shoddy Raid**
> **Bucheon Terminal Guild Master to Cooperate Fully with Hunter Association Investigation**

And now they were talking about going in with ten people. Just as the official was hesitating—

“Hey, mister. Hold on.”

The young man, who had been badgering him with a menacing scowl moments earlier, was now smiling.

“The numbers have to be roughly right anyway, don’t they?”

“Ah, yes. That would be good.”

“Then let’s take those guys along. Make it look good.”

The official followed the young man’s finger. A group of five had just entered the management office.

Two middle-aged men. Two young men. And…

One stunningly beautiful woman.

Judging by how the young man couldn’t take his eyes off her, his intentions were obvious.

“Good enough now?”

After quickly doing the math, the official picked up the envelope.

“No problem.”

The middle-aged official kindly explained the situation to us.

It was currently a safety-inspection period, which meant quite a few Guilds were facing delays in entering Gates. With our current numbers, we would either have to hire mercenaries or join forces with another Guild.

“You’re in luck. The people from Sangdong Guild are waiting, and they’re exactly five people short.”

“If we join them, how long will it take until we can enter the Gate?”

“We can process it immediately once you join.”

That worked great for us.

Team Leader Choi, who held the real decision-making power, nodded without objection.

“Then that sounds good.”

Just as Butler Kim, the Guild Master, signed the contract, an unexpected voice cut in.

“Nice to meet you. I’m Im Changsoo, the Team Leader from Sangdong Guild.”

His voice was smooth and easygoing, but his build was quite solid.

Unmistakable confidence radiated from him as he strode over.

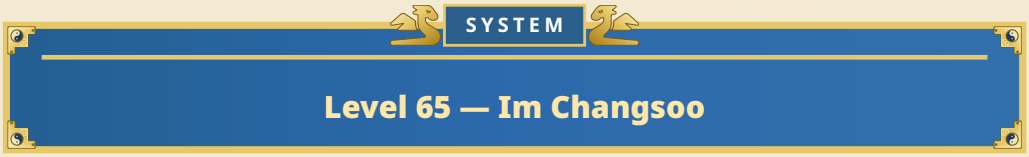
Someone from Sangdong Guild had every reason to be confident.

Sangdong Guild was one of the five leading mid-sized Guilds in the Bucheon area, with more than twenty B-rank Hunters alone.

He looked to be in his late twenties at most, yet he was already a Team Leader. That wasn't a position one could luck into over a game of cards.[421]

This guy's no pushover.

The Qi Sense I activated a moment later turned my guess into certainty.



And yet, his name sounded familiar. Where had I heard it before?

While I tilted my head, Butler Kim greeted him.

"Hello. I'm Kim Hwajong of Peace Guild."

We called him Butler Kim, Uncle, Kim Hyung,[422] and plenty of other things, and we knew he was only a figurehead Guild Master. But to an outsider, he obviously looked like the man in charge.

Im Changsoo answered with a bright smile.

"Ah, Peace Guild. I've heard quite a lot about you."

Im Kkeokjeong and Miss Song, who were standing nearby, whispered to each other.

"Miss Song, how long has our Guild been around?"

"Hmm. About two weeks, I think?"

"Raids? Have we done many?"

"What are you talking about? We haven't even started remodeling the Guild house yet. This is our first official raid."

"…"

A B-rank Hunter could hear everything, no matter how quietly someone spoke. Im Changsoo turned toward the two of them.

"And these people are?"

"They're members of our Guild."

His gaze passed over them—briefly over Im Kkeokjeong, then lingering a little longer on Miss Song.

"I see. I said something unnecessary, haha."

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[421] Go-stop is a Korean card game played with flower cards.

[422] *Hyung* is a familiar term a younger man uses for an older man, often an older brother or close acquaintance.

“Not at all.”

“In any case, this must be fate. Since we’re on the same team now, I look forward to working with you.”

“All right, then. We’ll go change into our gear and be right back.”

“We’ll wait for you in front of the Gate.”

Team Leader Choi watched Im Changsoo’s back as he walked away, his gleaming chainmail clanking with every step. His face was serious.

“That man…”

“Is there a problem?”

“His equipment is limited edition. That stuff is incredibly hard to get.”

“…”

Oh. Right. It did look expensive.

Hunters were the envy of society. Partly because they were the guardians who had protected humanity from the Great Cataclysm… but mainly because they made a lot of money.

Even I made over 100 million won[423] a year as a lowest-rank Hunter by working my ass off, so that said it all.

The problem was that we spent a lot, too.

The single biggest expense was equipment.

Magic Gems went into equipment as a matter of course, so no matter how carefully you weighed cost against performance, you couldn’t avoid spending a fortune. Then there were the regular maintenance costs and repair bills whenever something broke.

The heartbreak was one thing. Your bank balance got ripped apart too.

There was a reason equipment insurance existed.

In that regard, Team Leader Choi was the best employer ever.

He loaned us high-end equipment for free.

Rumble, rumble.

Team Leader Choi entered the changing room, pulling a suitcase behind him, and called us over.

“I picked out some decent equipment suited to each of your positions. Take one set each.”

It was a small suitcase, the sort you might use for a short trip. Im Kkeokjeong muttered in disappointment.

“Guess there isn’t one for me.”

[423] 100 million won is about $71,000 or €65,000.

The corners of Team Leader Choi's mouth curled up.

"Of course there is. If you knew what this was, you'd be shocked…"

"Oh, this is a suitcase with a space-expansion spell on it."

"…"

Nailed it.

My accurate prediction briefly wiped the smile off Team Leader Choi's face. But he quickly composed himself and continued.

"That's right. A space-expansion suitcase made by K Company. Nicholas, known as the greatest craftsman in North America…"

Clatter!

"Wow, it really is! Taekyung, look at this. It's huge inside!"

"It is."

"World-renowned designers also participated…"

"Wow, I've never seen anything like this before. I could probably sleep in here."

"Once you close the suitcase, you won't be able to get out until someone opens it."

"Really?"

"This product keeps stored items in optimal condition through proper temperature control and ventilation at all times…"

Click, click.

"This is awesome. What do you think? Does it suit me?"

"It fits you perfectly. I thought it was a tailored suit."

"You look good too. What's that?"

"It says it's a Black Drake Leather Set. I mean, it's a leather set."

"Really? If it's Team Leader Choi's, it must be good. Hahaha! Thanks, Team Leader Choi!"

"…Don't mention it."

Team Leader Choi had completely lost the will to fight by then and changed into his equipment without another word. Meanwhile, I checked each piece of equipment I was wearing.

Item Check.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Masterwork Black Drake Leather Set
Type: Armor
Grade: Peak
Description: An armor set made from the leather of the B-rank monster Black Drake. The work of a superb craftsman is evident.
Effect: Strength, Stamina, Agility, Toughness +10
— Full Set Effect is active.
Item Window
Masterwork Black Thorn Spear
Type: Spear
Grade: Peak
Description: A spear made from the spine of the B-rank monster Black Drake. It is both extremely hard and sharp. The work of a superb craftsman is evident.
Effect: Bleeding has a 90% chance to activate upon hitting an enemy.

After checking them, I had exactly one thought.

This is insane.

An armor set that gave me forty points simply by wearing it, plus a spear that could make an enemy bleed to death with nearly every stab.

The item information alone made it clear how incredible the effects were.

So this is what gear advantage feels like.

When I suddenly remembered my time in Murim, tears clouded my vision.

Armor, my ass.

I had fought in soft scraps of cloth and broken dozens of cheap spears. The people of Murim were the very definition of hard-boiled—the real tough guys.

“Maybe it’s because it’s designer gear, but it feels different right away.”

I turned my head and saw Im Kkeokjeong hopping up and down in place, his face flushed with excitement.

“It’s incredibly light, and I feel faster too. Is it just my imagination?”

“I doubt it.”

There was no way it was just his imagination. Team Leader Choi had prepared this equipment specifically for Im Kkeokjeong, a D-rank Hunter. Of course it was good.

Should I take a quick look?

Just as I was about to place my hand on the full plate armor Im Kkeokjeong was wearing, Team Leader Choi approached us, already fully equipped.

"If you're ready, let's head out."

"What about Butler Kim?"

"Out here, he's the Guild Master."

At Team Leader Choi's pointed correction, Butler Kim chuckled.

"It's fine. Besides… I'm always wearing my equipment."

As he spoke, he unbuttoned his suit jacket, revealing bracelets on both wrists and a necklace. They were no ordinary accessories, of course.

The necklace was set with a Magic Gem, while the bracelets were engraved with strange yet beautiful patterns.

"An artifact?"

"I find these more convenient than a staff."

Butler Kim answered modestly, but it was rare to see a mage dressed so lightly. Most wore at least some light armor or carried a staff for self-defense to improve their chances of survival.

Well, he's probably no ordinary mage.

Anyone from Ares Guild commanded respect.

I suddenly found myself curious about Butler Kim's past, but the question was wiped clean from my mind the next moment.

Knock, knock.

"Hey, guys. Are you still not done?"

"Ah, we're ready."

It was Miss Song's voice from outside the changing room. As soon as Team Leader Choi answered, the door eased open.

"Hurry up. People will be waiting."

"Whoa."

Her long, straight hair was tied up tightly, and she was wearing light leather armor. I swallowed a startled breath at the sight of her.

Can a person really be this beautiful?

It wasn't just love making me see her through rose-colored glasses. That was simply the truth. I knew that much just from seeing Im Kkeokjeong, who had treated her like a cute niece until now, swallow hard.

Gulp.

"…"

I'd better keep an eye on this guy.

If even Im Kkeokjeong was reacting like this, the other guys would be no exception. Any young guy who seemed even moderately capable would come by the truckload to hit on her.

Take Im Changsoo, for example. Im Changsoo, say. Or maybe Im Changsoo…

Im Changsoo. The young Team Leader from Sangdong Guild.

His face had been hovering in my mind since earlier.

I was sure I'd never seen him before.

And yet… why was he bothering me so much? Was it because that punk seemed interested in Miss Song?

"What are you doing? Aren't you coming out?"

"Ah, yes."

My thoughts were cut short. At Im Kkeokjeong's urging, I hurried out of the changing room.

Chapter 81

In front of the Gate, ten men and women dressed as Hunters were chatting in a friendly atmosphere.

“Oppas[424], we’re going to be okay, right?”

At the female Hunter’s question, a B-rank Hunter from Sangdong Guild thumped his breastplate.

“I told you not to worry. Don’t you trust us?”

“Of course I do. But I heard people died here last week.”

“Forget those idiots. They got themselves killed playing tough when they didn’t have the skills to back it up. Who else can they blame? Right, Changsoo hyung[425]?”

Im Changsoo, who had been listening quietly, blew a cloud of cigarette smoke into the air.

“If you’re nervous, go home. Don’t ruin the fucking mood.”

The atmosphere instantly turned cold. The female Hunter who had spoken first forced the corners of her mouth upward.

“No, oppa[426], I was just—”

“Shut up. What are you going to do?”

“…Sorry.”

“Then go curl up in a corner. I’ve got more than enough bitches to bring along without you.”

Despite his rough words and behavior, not one of them dared to object. They merely tried to lighten the mood with awkward smiles.

This sort of scene was both familiar and perfectly natural to Im Changsoo.

Idiots.

Gates were geese that laid golden eggs called Magic Gems, and Hunters were the laborers who harvested them. Born into a family of estate managers, he had started out on a completely different footing.

“If you’re not going to a hotel right now, quit hanging all over each other. It’ll be a pain in the ass if another shitty rumor starts spreading.”

“Hyung[427], you can trust these girls.”

“I don’t, asshole. Didn’t you say the same thing about the last ones?”

“Well, that was…”

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[424] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to. *Oppas* is its English plural.

[425] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

[426] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to. *Oppas* is its English plural.

[427] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

Sangdong Guild might have been a respectable mid-sized Guild that threw its weight around locally, but it wasn't powerful enough to ignore public scrutiny. Im Changsoo had already received several warnings from his father, the Guild Master, after messing with the wrong women.

"Let's make sure there aren't any problems, okay?"

"Yes, sir. We'll keep that in mind. Loyalty!"

"Tsk. At least you're good at answering."

Im Changsoo flicked away his half-burned cigarette. As if she had been waiting for it, someone beside him called out a spell.

"Wind."

A magically generated breeze sent the cigarette butt and its smell flying far away. The female mage who had cast the spell gave him a charming smile.

"I did good, right?"

Im Changsoo looked her up and down. She had a sleek figure and was an alluring beauty, and the two of them had a sort of sponsorship arrangement.

Despite her outstanding looks, she was a C-rank Hunter with pathetic skills. But being the Guild Master's son's lover had been enough to get her into Sangdong Guild.

Her house, her car, and countless designer goods—all of them had come out of Im Changsoo's pocket. But he had never once thought it was a waste.

Well, that was true until now.

But today, his mind had changed. Her figure, her looks, her entire air—all of it seemed tacky and cheap compared to the woman he had met about thirty minutes earlier.

Was her name Song Song?

Just thinking about her made his lower abdomen feel heavy.

She was a flower far too precious for some pathetic new Guild. He intended to pull her out without damaging a single root and plant her in his own flowerpot.

"Oppa[428], did something good happen? Why are you smiling like that?"

Im Changsoo didn't answer. Instead, he waved toward the five people who had appeared in the distance.

"Ah, over here!"

Of course, he didn't forget to add a quiet remark to his ex-girlfriend.

"Who the hell are you calling oppa[429], you fucking bitch?"

[428] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to. *Oppas* is its English plural.

[429] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to. *Oppas* is its English plural.

Horndog—or rather, Im Changsoo—spoke with a bright smile.

“You’re here. Ah, these are my team members.”

The people who appeared to belong to Sangdong Guild bowed their heads.

Including Im Changsoo, there were exactly five men and five women. Every one of them wore expensive, gleaming equipment that clearly prioritized design over practicality.

Especially…

Oh, wow.

When it came to the female Hunters, I had no idea where to look. Im Kkeokjeong, a married man with two children, whispered with a stiff expression.

“They’re incredible.”

“…”

I almost nodded before managing to stop myself.

Miss Song was looking at us with a displeased expression.

That aside…

Was this a raid or a blind date? If a bunch of handsome men and beautiful women paired off and entered a Gate while laughing and chatting, they were liable to end up dead.

Well, judging by their Levels and equipment, they would probably be fine.

“Is everyone here?”

The middle-aged official in charge of the Gate checked our numbers and Hunter licenses. It was one of the mandatory procedures before entering.

“Sangdong Guild. Five B-ranks and five C-ranks. Correct?”

Im Changsoo gave him a courteous smile.

“That’s right.”

“Then Peace Guild. Two B-ranks, two C-ranks, and…”

The official’s hand paused as he flipped through the Hunter licenses.

“One E-rank? Where is he?”

Im Kkeokjeong thrust his hairy arm into the air.

“Uh, that’s me.”

“What’s your position?”

“You’re not very observant, sir. Would I lug around a great brute of a shield like this if I were a mage? Heh heh.”

“You’re a tank.”

The official furrowed his brow.

A tank was exactly what the name suggested: a human shield who stood on the front line and blocked monster attacks. Because of the danger, tanks were among the best-paid Hunters, along with healers. They also had a high fatality rate.

“Why would an E-rank come here? As a tank, no less. Good grief.”

“You can make a lot of money in one go. Who knows? If the Magic Gems come pouring out, you’ve hit the jackpot.”

“Oppa[430], we’re really going to be okay today, right?”

“Don’t worry, Hye-rin. This oppa[431] will protect you.”

Murmurs spread among Im Changsoo’s team members. The official who had to let us enter was no exception.

“An E-rank tank…”

Butler Kim stepped forward at the concern in his voice.

“He is a veteran with twenty years of experience. He is also wearing sufficient equipment to prepare for any danger, so I don’t believe there will be a problem.”

“Veteran is good, of course. But you know what happened last week. Two C-rank tanks died. In a situation like this, letting him…”

That was when an unexpected ally appeared.

“Sir, is there any way you could allow it?”

It was Im Changsoo. He continued in a soft voice.

“We’ve already signed the cooperative raid contract, and after meeting such fine people, it would be a shame to render it invalid.”

“Well, I mean…”

“We’d be very grateful if you could show us a little flexibility… Please.”

What a strange guy. The words coming out of his mouth were all gratitude and requests, but his bearing was stiff and his manner was high-handed.

The official flinched for a moment, then sighed.

“All right. But Team Leader, you’ll have to keep them under control.”

“Of course.”

Keep them under control. What an unpleasant way to put it.

With Im Changsoo’s help, permission was granted, but an ant seemed to be crawling around in one corner of my chest.

Well, better to let it go.

Even Im Kkeokjeong, the person involved, looked completely unfazed. It would be ridiculous for me to take offense on his behalf.

“You may enter, then.”

At the official’s words, everyone stepped in front of the Gate. Ten Hunters from Sangdong Guild and five from Peace Guild. Fifteen people in total, including no fewer than seven B-rank Hunters—a highly elite raid team.

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[430] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to. *Oppas* is its English plural.

[431] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to. *Oppas* is its English plural.

“Well, then…”

Im Changsoo, who had naturally taken the lead, winked.

“See you inside the Gate.”

Whoosh!

As Im Changsoo disappeared beyond the field of magic, Miss Song muttered,

“What a creep.”

I agree.

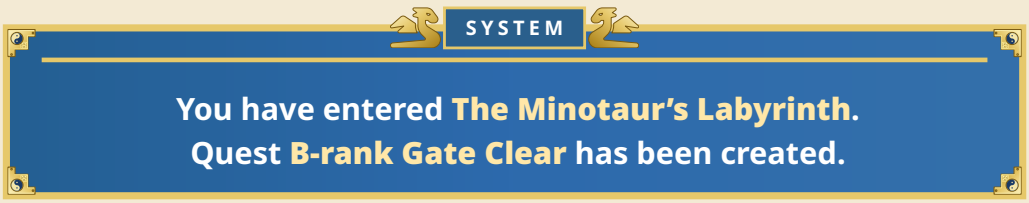
Whoosh.

The damp, sticky energy unique to magic wrapped around my body for a moment. When I opened my eyes, a new space unfolded before me.

The cavern was so vast that it couldn’t even be compared to an F-rank Gate. Three entrances gaped open like enormous maws. It was the same place we had seen in the video on the way here.

The only difference was…

Ding.



There was a System notification that only I could hear. And, on top of that, a Quest.

“All right, let’s check our numbers and equipment one more time before we go in.”

While everyone checked their belongings, I quietly moved to a corner of the cavern and muttered inwardly.

Check Quest.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
B-rank Gate Clear
You have entered a B-rank Gate for the first time in your life. Upon successfully completing the raid, you will receive a corresponding Reward. This applies only once.
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Clear the B-rank Gate *(Incomplete)*
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

What a refreshing start.

I had just closed the Quest window with a warm smile when—

“What are you doing over here by yourself?”

A voice suddenly came from behind me. I turned and saw Im Changsoo walking toward me.

“Me?”

I thought he had mistaken me for someone else, but apparently not.

“You’re Mr. Jang Taekyung from Peace Guild, right?”

“I’m Jin Taekyung.”

“Yes, Mr. Jang Taekyung.”

I wasn’t sure whether he was deaf or there was something wrong with my tongue, but I nodded anyway.

We’ll probably only see each other once, anyway.

He had helped us with the issue concerning Im Kkeokjeong, so I still felt a little grateful to him.

“Did you need something?”

“Haha, it’s nothing I’d call business. This is fate, so I thought we could at least exchange names. You heard my introduction earlier, so you already know who I am. I look forward to working with you.”

Someone once said you couldn’t spit in a smiling face. It was a little awkward, but I clasped the hand Im Changsoo offered with a broad smile on his face.

“Ah, yes. I look forward to working with you too.”

A Team Leader from another Guild—someone I had never even met before—had offered me a handshake first.

I had participated in cooperative raids several times over the past seven years and had plenty of experience as a day-labor Hunter, but this was the first time something like this had happened.

Then again, I was an F-rank back then.

In those days, people had treated me like air. Maybe being a C-rank Hunter meant I was finally being treated like a person. It left me with a strange feeling.

But why me?

The question was answered almost immediately.

"That's a Black Drake Leather Set, right?"

"Ah."

This guy's a Designer-Brand Junkie too.

Im Changsoo looked my equipment up and down, exclaiming in admiration.

"Wow, I've only ever seen this in pictures. Where did you buy it? Did you order it from overseas? Or get it in Cheongdam-dong[432]?"

"I rented it."

"You leased it from a company, then. I heard you're a C-rank Hunter, but can you really afford to maintain something like this? Ah, I'm sorry. I absolutely didn't mean anything by that. Did I offend you?"

Of course I'm offended, you moron.

But I wasn't stupid enough to let my true feelings show so openly.

What Im Changsoo had said was also a cold reality.

Still, this guy really has no tact.

I waved a hand with deliberate composure, mixing in a little self-deprecating humor.

"It's already breaking my back. Every penny I earn goes toward maintenance. The people around me call me crazy."

"Haha, but is there anything more important than your life? Right?"

"That's true."

"Then I suppose the same goes for the others."

"Sorry?"

"The others. The Peace Guild members. Their equipment looked pretty good too."

"Did it? I don't know much about that sort of thing."

Im Changsoo laughed as if he had heard an amusing joke.

"Come on. That's not something a person who spends a fortune leasing equipment gets to say."

The equipment was leased, but it hadn't cost me a fortune. Team Leader Choi had loaned it to me free of charge. I briefly considered explaining that, but soon abandoned the thought.

What would be the point?

Explaining it would only waste my breath.

[432] Cheongdam-dong is a Seoul district known for luxury shopping.

I was already tired of talking about equipment, so I gave him a vague answer.

“They’re all about the same as me.”

“I see.”

At that moment, one of Im Changsoo’s team members ran over and told him that preparations were complete.

“Oh, dear. We’ve been chatting for too long. I’d better go. I need to check on my team members one last time, and then we should all move together.”

“Take care.”

“Yes.”

Im Changsoo bowed politely and was about to leave when he suddenly asked,

“Oh, right. There’s something I’ve been meaning to ask you.”

“…?”

“Have we met somewhere before?”

I would have been overjoyed if Miss Song had asked me that, but hearing it from a male in heavy armor left me feeling less than pleased.

“This is our first meeting.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

I only thought his name sounded familiar. This was definitely our first meeting. At my firm answer, Im Changsoo’s smile deepened.

“All right, then. I’ll be going.”

What was that? Something about his final smile rubbed me the wrong way.

As I watched him walk away, Team Leader Choi approached without my noticing and asked,

“Do you know him?”

“No. He just said he wanted to be friends.”

“He didn’t make a recruitment offer?”

“Not at all. I think he only came over because he’s a gear nerd. He walked up out of nowhere and asked where I bought my equipment.”

“I bought it in Cheongdam-dong[433].”

“…”

I wasn’t asking.

“Changsoo hyung[434], why did you suddenly go talk to that bastard?”

“No reason. His equipment looked decent, so I sounded him out.”

[433] Cheongdam-dong is a Seoul district known for luxury shopping.

[434] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

“Holy crap, it really does. Is that stuff really his?”

“Use your brain, asshole. How could a C-rank wear something like that?”

“Then he leased it? Crazy bastard. The maintenance costs must be insane.”

“Leave him alone. It’s cute, watching him overextend himself trying to make something of himself.”

Im Changsoo let out a quiet laugh.

As expected, they were nothing special.

Admittedly, he had felt a little uneasy when they showed up out of nowhere decked out in expensive equipment. If he messed with the wrong people, things could get out of hand.

But now that he had them figured out, he felt at ease.

Song Song.

Money and ability. With only those two things, he believed he could do anything. Getting his hands on one woman would be no trouble at all.

“Let’s get moving. Pass it on.”

“Yes, sir!”

Chapter 82

Fifteen people in total. With nearly half of them B-rank Hunters, it had turned into a lavish raid team—even taking the Gate's rank into account.

"Were B-rank Hunters always this common?"

I agreed with Im Kkeokjeong.

"Seriously."

Before, even when I went looking for them, I had been lucky to catch a glimpse of their coat tails. They had always lived in a completely different world from people like Im Kkeokjeong and me.

"But you don't seem all that impressed, Taekyung."

"Me?"

"Yeah. I saw you chatting pretty comfortably with that other Team Leader earlier."

"It happens. We were just making small talk."

"It happens, my ass. Not long ago, you would've broken your neck trying to look up high enough to talk to one of them."

Was it really that bad?

Come to think of it, he wasn't wrong. I was simply the one who had changed.

They say the scenery changes when you change where you stand.

B-rank Hunters. Mountain ridges I couldn't reach even with my hand outstretched now stood right before me.

But the scenery wasn't as beautiful as I had imagined.

They're around Supreme First Rate? No, maybe First Rate martial artists.

Both the Levels I'd checked with Qi Sense and the amount of mana I felt from them put them at about that level. Needless to say, I was a cut above them, armed with the System's cheat-like advantages. Even compared to martial artists of the same Level, they would probably be a step below.

That's the difference between martial artists and Hunters.

Both sides had their strengths and weaknesses, but if they fought with nothing but their bodies, the Hunter would lose every time.

Martial artists learned internal energy cultivation techniques that allowed them to efficiently use the qi within their bodies, then maximized its power through martial arts.

A Hunter would need proper equipment and magic to stand a chance.

The conclusion was simple. Martial artists had the advantage in individual ability, while Hunters were superior in group combat and tactics.

And…

I'm a total cheat character.

I was both a Hunter and a martial artist—a martial artist and a Hunter. I possessed all the advantages of two classes that were alike yet fundamentally different.

Even more frightening was the fact that I was still growing rapidly through the System.

I kind of feel like the protagonist of a novel.

Maybe I should write an autobiography when I got old and retired.

Login Murim.

Something like that for the title.

To anyone else, it would sound like a fantasy novel.

“Everyone, assemble! Move into the formation I call out!”

At the shout, Im Kkeokjeong took a deep breath.

“So it’s starting.”

Im Kkeokjeong’s position was tank. He had to protect the team from the front.

Maybe it was the pressure of a B-rank Gate, but his usually smiling face had gone stiff.

“Can I do this?”

I patted him on the shoulder.

“You can.”

I wasn’t just saying that to make him feel better. The System window floating before my eyes was proof.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Matador's Full-Body Armor
Type: Armor
Grade: Peak
Description: Armor of the matador, by the matador, for the matador.
Effect: Strength, Stamina, Toughness +10
Against bovine-type monsters, All Stats +20.
Item Window
Matador's Shield
Type: Shield
Grade: Peak
Description: A shield of the matador, by the matador, for the matador. Dyed red with bull's blood, it is eerie just to look at.
Effect: Strength, Stamina, Toughness +10
Against bovine-type monsters, has a chance to activate **Taunt**.
Against bovine-type monsters, has a chance to activate **Hallucination**.

Honestly, I thought it would be impossible at first.

But this was enough to put my mind at ease. At least here, in The Minotaur's Labyrinth, Im Kkeokjeong would be able to perform admirably as a tank.

"Hunter Im."

The sponsor—or rather, Team Leader Choi—approached quietly and spoke with a serious expression.

"Put it on carefully. It's part of my prized collection."

"..."

"..."

He sure knows how to say something nice.

Im Kkeokjeong took the lead as the tank. Once Butler Kim, the mage, and Miss Song-i, the healer, moved to the rear, only Team Leader Choi remained beside me.

"...Why are you looking at me like that?"

Why else? I wanted him to switch positions with Miss Song-i.

How nice would it be to walk side by side, enjoying a pleasant stroll through the Gate? We could even save each other if monsters showed up.

The heavens clearly aren't on my side.

Even when I raised my head in lament, all I saw was the damp cavern ceiling. Of course, it was incomparably higher than the ceiling of an F-rank Gate.

"It's definitely huge."

"It's a B-rank Gate."

The higher a Gate's rank, the larger its interior and the stronger the monsters that appeared within it. Of course, D-rank was as high as I'd ever gone, so this was my first time inside anything higher. That was what people said, anyway.

"In some cases, you even have to climb a snow-covered mountain. I went once two years ago. It was horrible."

"Oh, was there some kind of accident?"

"No. My boots weren't enchanted with waterproofing."

"…"

"I have cold hands and feet."

"…"

"Ah, both of those were jokes."

Of course they were jokes. How could someone above Level 60 have cold hands and feet?

I was staring at Team Leader Choi with an incredulous expression when—

Drrrk.

"Hm?"

"Is something wrong?"

"Wait. Just a moment."

Was I imagining things?

No.

A faint vibration had traveled through the cavern floor. It lasted only an instant, but I had definitely felt it.

Drrrk.

The second vibration was clearer and more obvious.

Several people had already noticed it and begun watching the area ahead. Im Changsoo was one of them.

"Prepare for battle!"

His short shout was quick and composed. With half his team being B-rank Hunters and excellent gear at their disposal, he had no reason to panic.

There was just one problem.

"Watch the holes!"

This was a labyrinth. There were five wide-open holes right in front of us.

It was difficult to determine exactly where the monsters were coming from based on the vibrations in the ground alone.

“Where are they?”

“…”

Who is Im Changsoo asking? It’s not like the Minotaurs are going to answer him.

“—Moooooo!”

“There! The hole on the far left!”

“…Is this for real?”

I could hardly believe the sight even as I watched it.

I clicked my tongue and gripped my spear. The Masterwork Black Thorn Spear—a vicious weapon with a high chance of putting an enemy into the Bleeding state.

“Doesn’t the grip feel great? I applied the finishing coat very carefully—”

There’s another vicious thing here.

If Team Leader Choi died, I had no doubt he would fall straight into the tongue-pulling hell.[435]

The next moment—

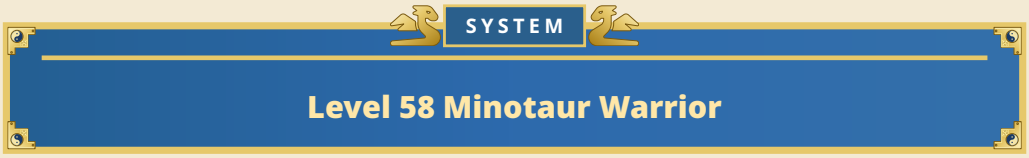
Boom. Boom. Boom.

“—Moooooooo!”

They burst out of the darkness.

Their bodies resembled humans, but their physiques were too massive to be human, and their muscles were grotesquely swollen.

A rectangular Level window floated above two horns stained with dust and someone’s blood.



“—Moooooo!”

They looked far more vivid and imposing in person than they had in the video, but…

“That’s all?”

“There’s only one?”

There really was just one.

Could that Minotaur have gotten lost in the labyrinth, too?

“At that level, we should be able to handle it without ranged support, shouldn’t we?”

“Hye-rin, I’ll be right back.”

[435]The tongue-pulling hell is a Buddhist hell where liars and slanderers are punished by having their tongues pulled out.

The Sangdong Guild members confidently stepped forward. Two tanks and two damage dealers, all of them B-rank Hunters.

Their intention to show off in front of the women was painfully obvious.

Oh, you morons.

Guys like that always fooled around and ended up dead. Of course, that probably wouldn't happen because of a single Minotaur.

"If you're going to do it, finish it quickly."

With Im Changsoo's permission, the four men drew their weapons and started toward the monster.

That was when—

Boom. Boom.

"Hm?"

"—Moo."

A Minotaur popped out of the second of the five holes.

"Oh, now there are two."

"That one's a little smaller. It looks weaker, so you take it."

"What the hell are you saying? Says the weakest bastard here."

Boom. Boom.

"—Moo."

The third hole.

"Oh, three. At this rate, this might actually be a pretty fun fight."

"Anyone who gets so much as a scratch buys drinks tonight. How about it?"

"I'm in."

"I'm in. The guy who suggests these things always ends up paying."

Boom. Boom.

"—Moo."

"Ah, shit. What is this?"

"Four might be a bit much."

"We should probably form up and take them out one at a time."

"Agreed."

Team Leader Choi, who had been watching the situation, scratched his neck.

"Maybe we should wait a little longer before coming up with a strategy."

"Huh?"

"The holes. Don't you get the feeling more might come out?"

"No way. It's not like they're introducing Olympic athletes."

Boom-boom-boom-boom!

He was right.

Lane five—no, the fifth hole—had news for us, too.

The only unexpected part was that this time, it wasn't alone.

"—Moooooo!"

Maybe it had a lot of friends. Four Minotaurs came stampeding out together.

Including the ones that had already appeared, there were eight in total. Four B-rank Hunters had no chance against that many.

Team Leader Choi spoke.

"What do you think?"

"It might be difficult."

Difficult, my ass. If you don't want to die, stay behind the tank.

I had toned it down for the benefit of the ears around us.

"What about you, Mr. Taekyung?"

"Me?"

"Yes. You, Mr. Taekyung."

"Hmm."

Minotaurs were B-rank monsters, and their Levels were in the mid-to-late fifties.

For a martial artist, that would be close to Supreme First Rate. But if I fought them, I would have to account for all sorts of variables.

Simply put, I would have to fight them to know.

"I'm not sure."

"You're not sure… Do you know something?"

Team Leader Choi stared at me with a strange look in his eyes.

"Most C-rank Hunters don't answer like that. They wouldn't take time to think about a question like that, much less take it seriously."

I felt a sudden twinge of unease.

I had no reason to hide my strength, but I also had no desire to brag about it to the whole neighborhood.

For now, I wanted to avoid attention and keep it as my own secret. A Hunter who was just a little more capable than everyone else. That was all.

"I've known this for a while, but you really are an interesting person, Jin Taekyung."

"No, wait, Team Leader. I think there may be some misunderstanding here."

I had just begun to speak when—

"Haha, I see. Listening to you, even I'm getting interested."

Im Changsoo suddenly cut in, his gaze sweeping over Team Leader Choi and me.

"You were having such an interesting conversation that I couldn't help overhearing some of it. You don't mind, do you?"

Was it my imagination, or did that sound like "If you do mind, what are you going to do about it?"

“For a C-rank with fuck-all to his name, you sure had a lot to say about Minotaurs and whatnot. You were practically writing a novel.”

Ah. So I wasn’t imagining it.

I looked at Im Changsoo with fresh eyes.

It suits him.

Everyone had clothes that suited them. The same went for smiles and attitudes.

That was how Im Changsoo looked to me now. The mockery gathered in the raised corners of his mouth suited him perfectly. It was practically made for him.

“I didn’t mean to offend you.”

At Team Leader Choi’s characteristically impassive expression and tone, Im Changsoo let out a short laugh.

“Why would I be offended? It’s the truth. These guys are fucking lousy. They only look impressive because people keep calling them B-rank. Among B-ranks, they’re complete bottom-of-the-barrel trash. But…”

Im Changsoo jerked his chin toward me.

“They’re still better than a C-rank. Isn’t that right, Mr. Jang Taekyung?”

I finally said what I had been holding back all this time.

“It’s Jin Taekyung.”

“Whether you’re Jin Taekyung or Jang Taekyung, I don’t care what your surname is.”

“Then should I call you Shit Changsoo?”

“What?”

“Im Changsoo or Shit Changsoo. I don’t care what your surname is either.”

The smile disappeared from Im Changsoo’s face.

Chapter 83

Im Changsoo's attention had been fixed entirely on Song Song for some time.

Damn, she sure knows how to play hard to get.

He had deliberately hovered around her and tried striking up conversations in passing several times, but Song Song's responses had been utterly flat.

"Oh, okay."

"Thank you."

"I understand."

For all his effort, the results were pathetic.

What a picky bitch.

They said women cared about a man's face when they were young, then his body and ability as they got older. Im Changsoo possessed all three, and he had never failed to pick up a woman.

There had been women who grew disgusted with his casual approach to relationships and left him first, and others he had grown tired of and dumped before they could leave.

But he had never encountered indifference like this.

She sure knows she's hot shit.

Even when irritation began to rise, it melted away whenever he looked at Song Song's sleek figure and dreamlike face. Her fragrant natural scent, worlds apart from the smell of other women's cosmetics, helped too.

Don't get impatient. She'll fall for me eventually.

There was still plenty of time. The Minotaur's Labyrinth was a labyrinth in the truest sense of the word. Raid times could stretch to twice as long as those of other Gates.

That was more than enough time to pick up one woman.

There was only one problem…

One guy keeps getting on my nerves.

Choi Minwoo, was it? He looked more at home in a fashion magazine than inside a Gate. His polished face, his long limbs—even his characteristically impassive expression irritated Im Changsoo.

The rest are just fucking idiots.

The old geezer who did nothing but chuckle and the bandit-like middle-aged man had been out of the running from the start.

There was one more young guy named Jang Taekyung, but he didn't even qualify as competition.

He's weirdly irritating, though.

A run-of-the-mill C-rank Hunter. He wasn't even part of a major Guild, just some small-timer scraping by with high-end equipment he'd leased despite it being above his station. Yet there was something strangely confident about his attitude and the way he spoke.

Toward the end of their conversation a moment ago, Taekyung had even seemed annoyed with him.

Trying to save face, are we?

With the two irritating bastards, Jang Taekyung and Choi Minwoo, standing together, it was only natural that Im Changsoo kept his eyes and ears trained on them.

—Mooooo!

It happened as the Minotaurs began appearing one after another.

"What do you think?"

"It would probably be difficult, wouldn't it?"

Well, look at these bastards.

Im Changsoo had just been about to call his men back, but he closed his mouth and listened instead.

"What about you, Mr. Taekyung?"

"Me?"

That alone was absurd enough, but the answer that came a moment later was even more ridiculous.

"I'm not sure."

A C-rank Hunter facing eight Minotaurs, and what? He wasn't sure?

The bastard would be a corpse within a minute even in a one-on-one fight. He was all mouth.

Crazy bastards. Go ahead and write a novel.

Im Changsoo let out a short laugh, then suddenly paused.

An idea had flashed through his mind. This was his chance to humiliate the two men he disliked in front of Song Song.

That was why he abruptly stepped between them.

"You were having such an interesting conversation that I couldn't help overhearing some of it. You don't mind, do you?"

He intended to make them apologize, laugh in their faces, and make it unmistakably clear who held the upper hand.

But then…

"Then should I call you Shit Changsoo?"

"What?"

"Im Changsoo or Shit Changsoo. I don't care what your surname is."

Shit Changsoo.

Im Changsoo's brain froze at an insult unlike anything he had ever heard in his life.

Silence fell all around us.

The Sangdong Guild. The Peace Guild.

Even the Minotaurs seemed to stop mooing.

In that suffocating silence, the man's tightly closed mouth finally opened.

"…You little shit."

At this point, using polite speech would have been ridiculous.

I gave him an equally breezy answer.

"What, you little shit?"

"You really… Are you insane?"

"Everyone on Earth is already spinning. Haven't you heard of geocentrism, you ignorant bastard?"

That was when Team Leader Choi cut in.

"That's heliocentrism. Geocentrism is the cosmological view that the Earth is fixed and unmoving at the center of the universe, while the Moon, Sun, and planets orbit around it, each traveling along its own celestial sphere…"

Smack.

Im Kkeokjeong's enormous, cauldron-lid-sized hand had approached so quietly that no one noticed it until it clamped over Team Leader Choi's mouth.

"Mmph. What are you doing? Mmph, mmph."

…

I wished he would just drop dead right there.

There was a limit to how oblivious one person could be. I was beginning to wonder whether the Sangdong Guild had paid him off.

"I can't believe I'm talking to people like you."

Im Changsoo stared at Team Leader Choi and me in baffled disbelief.

"How did airheaded bastards like you even become Hunters?"

"What, do they recruit based on school grades? Get a TOEIC[436] score of 900 and you're B-rank, and if you can speak Chinese, you're A-rank?"

"You'd better shut that mouth if you want to live a long time."

"Wow, threats now? I'm so scared I won't even be able to piss in the Sangdong Guild's direction."

Im Changsoo ground his teeth, sparks flying from his eyes.

[436] TOEIC is a standardized English-language test widely used in South Korea for employment qualifications.

"You seem to have forgotten… This is a Gate."

"I know, asshole. I also know there are eight Minotaurs coming toward us from over there."

Speak of the devil.

Right on cue, a bull's bellow echoed through the cavern.

—Moooooo!

"They're coming!"

"What do we do?"

"What do you think? Get back! Hurry!"

Boom. Boom. Boom.

The cavern floor shook with every step the Minotaur herd took.

Watching his team members come racing back at full speed, Im Changsoo spat out a wad of phlegm.

"Consider yourself lucky."

"I tend to be pretty lucky."

Thanks to the System, it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say I was living a second life. I'd been through hardships that could have killed me, but when it came to luck, mine was incredible.

"We'll settle this after I deal with those bastards."

"That works, too."

"I hope you're prepared to take responsibility for what you said."

"I think I can handle that."

I looked at the Level window floating above his head.

Level 65. High.

He was nearly ten Levels above the rest of his team, which meant he was probably quite capable even among B-rank Hunters.

Of course, he still wasn't as good as me.

Well, character and ability aren't proportional.

Hunters weren't selected based on TOEIC[437] scores, school grades, or personality-and-aptitude tests.

I shook my head and turned away.

"How about now?"

[437] TOEIC is a standardized English-language test widely used in South Korea for employment qualifications.

"…?"

"The Minotaurs. Didn't you say you were confident you could handle them alone?"

Ah. I had a rough idea of what he was getting at.

His intentions were obvious from his tone and expression, and a short laugh escaped me.

"I don't remember saying anything like that."

"You should take responsibility for what you said."

"You're too childish. I can't indulge you. If you have a problem, settle it one-on-one after the raid."

Butler Kim and Miss Song-i, who had been watching the situation with calm expressions, spoke up as well.

"It would be best if both of you calmed down."

"Excuse me, but don't you think this is a bad time?"

Boom-boom-boom.

Even now, the Minotaur herd was drawing closer by the second.

It was fortunate they were approaching cautiously. If they had wanted to, the battle could have started long ago.

"You heard them, right? Don't put innocent people in danger. We'll deal with this later…"

"Five bills."

"Huh?"

Im Changsoo spread all five fingers wide.

That wasn't five stars… it was five bills.

"Is that what I think it is?"

"The Minotaur herd over there. Take them down by yourself, and I'll give you five big bills per head."

"Big bills?"

"Yeah. Big bills."

That meant fifty million won[438] per Minotaur, or four hundred million won[439] for all eight.

Even for me, now that I was a C-rank Hunter, that was a considerable sum.

But…

I couldn't let everyone see how weak I was to money, especially Miss Song.

This was a matter of pride!

Miss Song-i. Can you hear my heart?

I gave her a soulful look and answered.

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[438] Fifty million won is about $36,000 or €32,000.

[439] Four hundred million won is about $290,000 or €260,000.

"I refuse."

Im Changsoo's eyebrow twitched.

"Even if I give you all rights to the byproducts?"

"No."

"Magic Gems might come out of them."

"Still no."

My answer was as firm as a juvenile court judge's. Im Changsoo bit his lip.

"What a pointlessly proud bastard. I'm offering four billion won[440] and all rights to the byproducts, and you're refusing?"

"Get lost… Wait. What did you just say?"

Had I heard him wrong?

For several seconds, all kinds of thoughts raced through my mind. Only after sorting them out did I finally manage to part my lips.

"How much? Four billion won[441]?"

"Didn't I say? Five big bills."

"…"

"Then… five hundred million won[442] per Minotaur?"

You should've said five fucking huge bills.

Four billion won[443].

The mind-boggling sum left not only me, but Miss Song and Im Kkeokjeong gaping.

Why's this bastard such a big spender?

He was the team leader of a mid-sized Guild and a B-rank Hunter, so he probably earned a lot.

But casually offering billions of won[444] like this was absurd.

"You're giving me four billion won[445] just like that?"

"Just? That won't do. This is a bet."

"What kind of bet?"

"I need something to gain, too."

The corners of Im Changsoo's lips twisted upward.

"If you die or run away, every reward I've offered so far is void. On top of that…"

His head slowly turned.

His gaze stopped on one person.

"Me?"

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[440] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[441] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[442] Five hundred million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[443] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[444] "Billions of won" here means roughly two to nine billion won: about $1.4–6.4 million or €1.3–5.8 million.

[445] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

"Yes. I'd like to invite Miss Song Song to join our Guild."

Im Changsoo bowed politely.

The sudden change in attitude was so different from how he had acted until now that it was downright creepy.

"Ugh, that's giving me goose bumps. Just act the way you were before. It looks much better than putting on a fake act."

"..."

"..."

Miss Song-i certainly had an honest personality.

She shuddered as if she really had gotten goose bumps, then folded her arms.

"Shit Chang—no, Im Changsoo, right?"

"...Yes."

"Okay. I'll be blunt. You're not my type."

Her blunt declaration came in like a 160-kilometer-per-hour[446] fastball, tight and inside. Im Changsoo's gaze wavered.

"You're tall and handsome, but you look exactly like the cheating type. And I hate wind, you see.[447] I finally got my hair looking nice, and if the wind musses it up... Ah, no, that's not what I meant, was it?"

"Y-yes? Yes?"

"Anyway, you're not my type. I absolutely can't stand womanizers who flaunt their money."

I had never seen Im Changsoo look so dumbfounded.

To anyone else, I probably had the same expression right now.

"Oh, that look you just had was kind of okay. But I've been watching you for a while, and your personality is kind of... You can tell that yourself, can't you?"

Im Changsoo barely managed to compose his expression before answering.

"We can work those things out one by one."

"Do you really have to taste something to know whether it's shit or soybean paste? You don't seem interested in anything but bumping bellies with me. Am I right?"

"...!"

"...!"

Everyone, myself included, was left gaping.

She toyed with her hair as if bashful while delivering one line after another, each blow landing like a nuclear bomb.

"It's not like I particularly dislike the Sangdong Guild."

Im Changsoo, who had been taking hit after hit without a break, brightened and asked:

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[446] 160 kilometers per hour is about 99 miles per hour.

[447] The Korean word *baram* can mean either "wind" or an affair, making her next line a deliberate pun.

"Really?"

"Yes. I can always switch again anyway."

"…"

Miss Song, are you a genius?

After delivering a massive fuck-you with an innocent expression, Miss Song continued.

"But I'd need to ask permission before switching Guilds. Right, Guild Master?"

"Ah, of course."

Butler Kim had been watching with an interested look in his eyes. Miss Song turned toward Team Leader Choi.

"Team Leader, what do you think?"

"What do you mean? About you switching Guilds?"

"If we lose this bet, that's what will happen, right?"

Team Leader Choi calmly nodded.

"Go ahead."

"Isn't that a little too easy an answer?"

"It was an easy question, so I answered easily."

For just a moment, I thought I saw hurt in Miss Song's eyes.

No, surely not.

The emotion had passed too quickly for me to be certain.

Returning to her frank, easygoing self, Miss Song turned to Im Changsoo.

"Then I'm in on the bet. What about you, Mr. Taekyung?"

"I…"

I thought it over for a while.

From the moment I first heard Team Leader Choi's question, a strange certainty had already taken root deep in my heart.

The certainty that I was stronger than those bastards.

"I'll take the bet."

A smile spread across Team Leader Choi's lips.

"I'll join in, too. A bet is more fun when the stakes are high, isn't it?"

"Wow, look at you. A real gambler. How much?"

"Four billion won.[448] Of course, I'm betting that Jin Taekyung will take down all eight."

"What?"

Im Changsoo stared at Team Leader Choi for a moment, then let out a short laugh.

"You're an interesting bunch. One of you is desperate to get himself killed, and the other is dying to throw away his money."

[448] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

"So what's your answer?"
"Obviously, yes."
"Should we write up a contract?"
"A contract? What do you take me for? Once I give my word, I keep it. You don't have to keep yours. I'll make you keep it. Everyone, move back!"
At that moment, the enormous, damp cavern transformed into a Colosseum.
An arena with an absurd amount of money at stake.
And I was the gladiator who had to fight the Minotaur herd.
"Team Leader Choi. What will you do if I lose?"
"You will win."
Where did that confidence come from?
Faith in himself? Or faith in what he'd seen of me so far?
It didn't matter.
I would simply do my best to achieve my goal.
Boom-boom-boom-boom-boom!
—Moooooo!
Twenty meters[449] ahead, I could see every one of them clearly.
Hot breath steaming from their nostrils. Heat. Muscles. Weapons held high.
This is my first time fighting a cow.
It should be an interesting experience.
I gripped my spear and charged at the herd like a bullfighter.

[449] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

Chapter 84

Im Kkeokjeong thought.

This is insane.

Jin Taekyung was a C-rank Hunter. A Minotaur, on the other hand, was a B-rank monster.

And there wasn't just one. There were eight. To Im Kkeokjeong, this went beyond reckless. It was hopeless.

What the hell does money matter?

Four billion won[450] was certainly enough to change a person's life, but it wasn't worth dying for. Im Changsoo had blinded Jin Taekyung with money, and Taekyung had lost his ability to think clearly.

I have to stop him. I have to.

Those vicious bastards from Sangdong Guild, Butler Kim for not stopping him, even Team Leader Choi—they were all insane. He had to keep his cherished little brother from dying a pointless death.

"Taekyung!"

It was at that very moment, when Im Kkeokjeong was about to reach out toward Jin Taekyung, who had just gripped his spear at the ready.

Whoosh—

"…Huh?"

With a rush of wind, Jin Taekyung vanished. He began sprinting at a speed Im Kkeokjeong, an E-rank Hunter, could neither match nor properly see.

It all happened in the blink of an eye. Im Kkeokjeong let out a dazed sound.

"Uh, uh-oh."

What was this? What was happening? Had Taekyung always been this strong? No, wait. Could a C-rank Hunter really move that fast?

Whooooooosh!

A black bolt of lightning shot across the cavern.

One step. Two steps. Three steps.

The distance of several dozen meters[451] vanished in an instant, and the spearhead flashed.

Swoooosh! Slice!

The Minotaur's enormous, over-three-meter-tall[452] body tilted to one side.

The thick neck that should have risen above its shoulders was already gone.

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[450] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[451] Several dozen meters is roughly 100–300 ft.

[452] Over three meters is over 9.8 ft.

For one moment, it seemed as if the half-human, half-beast creature with a human body and a bull's head were nothing more than an ordinary person.

Thump.

The head, severed in an instant, dropped to the cavern floor.

Crash.

The headless monster collapsed. Blood gushed from the cleanly severed stump of its neck.

"What the…!"

Someone's voice spoke for everyone's thoughts.

Amid the invisible shock and stunned disbelief, one person grinned.

"This is doable."

That one remark delivered the final blow.

Im Kkeokjeong's legs gave out, and Im Changsoo muttered without realizing it.

"Fuck… my four billion.[453]"

Minotaurs had bodies specialized for close-quarters combat.

Like any medium-sized monster, they were huge, packed with incredibly dense muscle, and armed with heavy weapons such as maces and axes.

Boom!

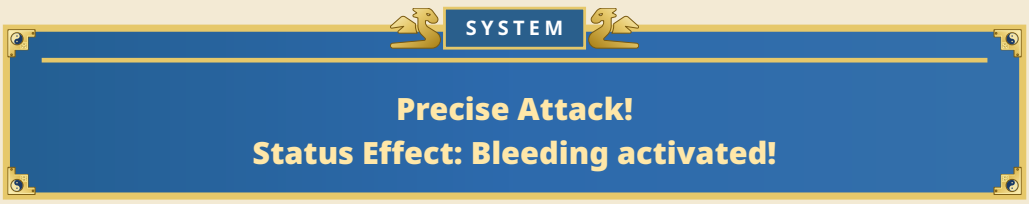
But what good was any of that if they couldn't land a hit?

No matter how hard they swung, all they could do was smash the innocent cavern floor.

I'll give them one thing. They're strong.

But strength alone didn't win fights. I slipped inside one monster's guard and drove my spear into its lower abdomen.

Schlk.



—Mooooo.

The Minotaur's cry was pitiful. It had already lost too much blood to charge in as ferociously as before. That attack moments ago had probably been the One Strike it made with the last of its strength.

—Moo. Mooooo.

[453] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

I approached the creature as it staggered backward.

Looking into those calf-like eyes almost made me feel sorry for it…

Like hell.

All I could see was a stack of five hundred million won.[454]

“In your next life, please be born in Hoengseong, Gangwon Province.”[455]

—Mooooo!

Slice.

The Minotaur breathed its last.

That made eight enormous pools of blood.

And eight monster corpses.

Ding.

The cheerful System notification was the movie’s background music. The real highlight of the movie was something else entirely.

I turned around with a wide smile.

“Now, for the fun part—the settlement.”

Among the people engulfed in shock and silence, one person stood out in particular.

I began settling the accounts loudly enough for the half-frozen Im Changsoo to hear.

“Let’s see. Five hundred million[456] per head to start with…”

He flinched.

“One, two, three, four… Eight of them. Four billion[457] in total. Wow, a few of them even dropped Magic Gems. You said all the byproducts were mine, too, right?”

He flinched again. And again.

“Changsoo. Why aren’t you answering? Don’t tell me you lied to me.”

Im Changsoo forced an awkward smile.

“Of course not.”

“Watch your tone.”

“How could that possibly be the case? I was just…”

“Just what?”

“Mr. Taekyung, if you could listen to me for a moment…”

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[454] Five hundred million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[455] Hoengseong is known for its Korean beef cattle.

[456] Five hundred million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[457] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

“Mr. Taekyung? I’ve been meaning to ask you this for a while. How old is our Changsoo?”

“…I’m twenty-five.”

“Oh, my. What a cheeky little shit. You’re only twenty-five, and you’ve been acting that disrespectfully toward your elders?”

“…”

“Did someone cut your tongue in half? You kept spitting out casual speech, so I thought you were ninety-five. And why does your face look so weathered? You didn’t register your birth late, did you?”

As I kept going, Im Changsoo’s face flushed bright red with anger.

“Keep that expression under control. Turn into a Hongik Ingan one more time, and I’ll make you genuinely red.”[458]

“I’m… sorry.”

After barely managing to compose his expression, he cautiously opened his mouth.

“Um, may I ask you one thing?”

“Ask.”

“Are you really a C-rank Hunter…?”

“Yeah. I am.”

Im Changsoo looked back and forth between me and the sprawled Minotaur corpses, his eyes filled with disbelief.

“What? Why?”

“If you’d rather not reveal it, you don’t have to tell me.”

“Think whatever you want.”

“Oh, no. That’s not what I meant.”

He denied it, but there was no doubt his imagination was running wild.

He had thought I was an ordinary C-rank Hunter, yet I had just crushed eight B-rank monsters in a head-on fight.

That’s right. Imagine away.

There was nothing to gain from antagonizing Sangdong Guild for no reason. Since they were bowing their heads on their own, I was simply grateful.

“So, perhaps you’re laundering your identity—no, you aren’t. You wouldn’t be. Right.”

Im Changsoo had been about to spout some nonsense, but one sidelong glance at my spear made him change the subject.

This guy’s reactions were kind of fun.

“So?”

[458] *Hongik Ingan*, meaning “to broadly benefit humanity,” is Korea’s national founding ideal. Taekyung plays on *hong*, which can also mean “red,” to joke about Im Changsoo’s face.

“Pardon?”

“Don’t ‘pardon’ me. You have to pay me. Four billion.[459]”

To be honest, I was a little worried that he might tell me to go to hell.

Four billion won[460] wasn’t pocket change. It was a huge sum of money that ordinary people could hardly hope to lay their hands on even after working their entire lives.

But Im Changsoo was different.

“Ah, of course I’ll pay you.”

“…You’re sure?”

“Yes. I keep my promises.”

His answer was so straightforward that it was almost suspicious.

No matter how much money a B-rank Hunter made, there was such a thing as an average income. Yet Im Changsoo talked about several billion won[461] as casually as if it were a thousand-won bill[462] in his pocket.

“You’re not going to disappear after saying that, are you? If you pretend none of this happened because we didn’t sign a contract, I’ll be very disappointed.”

I casually stroked my spear, and he flinched violently.

“Absolutely not. Absolutely not. I can easily afford that.”

“Hmm. You must make pretty good money. Sangdong Guild treats you well?”

“No. I’m treated the same as everyone else.”

“Of course there isn’t. It’s not like you’re the Guild Master’s son or something. Why would they treat you especially well?”

“…”

“…?”

“…”

Something about the atmosphere felt strange.

After thinking it over, I asked, “What’s your father’s name?”

“Im Chunsu.”

“What’s the Sangdong Guild Master’s name?”

“Im Chunsu.”

What a strange coincidence. Im Changsoo’s father and the Sangdong Guild Master had the same name.

Then again, the world was a big place, and plenty of people shared the same name.

“Hey, I’m only asking just in case, so forgive me for prying… but what does your father do for a living?”

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[459] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[460] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[461] Several billion won—roughly two to nine billion—is about $1.4–6.4 million or €1.3–5.8 million.

[462] One thousand won is about $0.71 or €0.65.

"He's a Hunter."

"Just a Hunter?"

"He runs a Guild."

"Oh, I see."

This bastard was the Sangdong Guild Master's son.

A brief silence passed, and in that short interval, I realized what had seemed so familiar about Im Changsoo.

"Are you that guy?"

"A dog?"

"No, I've heard about you before."

It was a story I'd heard around this time two years ago and let go in one ear and out the other.

The Sangdong Guild Master's only son, born late in his life, had awakened as a B-rank Hunter and secured a position in his father's Guild. But he was such a womanizer that he had become a constant headache.

And the nickname he had earned was…

"Horndog. Right?"

Im Changsoo answered by hanging his head.

It was an embarrassing nickname to hear in front of other people, to be sure.

But since I had to collect four billion won,[463] I comforted him in a warm voice.

"It's okay, man. Guys can be like that sometimes. I used to dream of living like you, too."

But reality was cruel, and that dream had seeped into a hundred-terabyte USB drive.

Jinho hyung,[464] a renowned authority in the world of porn, once borrowed my USB. When he showed up again, he had a hollow-eyed expression and left me with a one-line review.

This should be designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Anyway.

Im Changsoo lifted his head at my warm consolation.

"Really?"

Of course not. Did I look like the kind of guy who hit on just any woman? I was the sunflower of this era, gazing at only one person in the entire world—Miss Song-i…

Wait a second. This bastard had hit on Miss Song-i earlier.

"You little shit."

"Ack!"

---

[463] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[464] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

Frightened before I had even done anything, Im Changsoo reflexively placed his hand on his sword hilt.

Shing. Clack.

But the blade had barely made it halfway out before it was forced back into its sheath.

I had closed the distance like lightning, pressing down on his sword hilt as I kicked his legs out from under him.

Crash!

He lost his balance and fell. When I pressed down on his neck, his face went white.

“Ghk! Cough!”

“You little bastard. Where do you get off pulling that thing on me?”

Getting beaten by Jin Mukyung had certainly paid off.

In the past, I wouldn’t have been able to subdue a B-rank Hunter with such a simple, fluid movement. Im Changsoo was probably surprised, but I was even more surprised.

“This is a Gate, you idiot. You said so yourself earlier. Did you already forget?”

“I’m sorry! I’m sorry!”

I wanted to beat him senseless, but since it had only been an attempt, I decided to let him off.

It absolutely wasn’t because I hadn’t received the four billion[465] yet.

“Damages.”

“Ghk. What?”

“You drew your sword. Don’t you know that’s attempted murder? And you owe me and Miss Song-i—no, all our Guild members—a sincere apology.”

“What are you talking about?”

Im Changsoo looked around at the others with an aggrieved expression, but no one came to his aid.

His team members merely shrank back whenever my gaze landed on them. Meanwhile, our Guild members, who had been watching the spectacle, took it one step further.

“Drawing a sword on a member of a partner Guild. Well, I never.”

Butler Kim clicked his tongue as if he felt sorry for him.

“You’re only doing this because you don’t want to pay, aren’t you? My goodness, Changsoo, that’s so low. Isn’t it, Uncle?”

“Hmm? Uh-huh. What a nasty young man!”

Miss Song and Im Kkeokjeong delivered a lowlife-and-nasty-man combo.

Then Team Leader Choi dealt the final blow.

[465] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

“Now, would everyone take a look at my helmet? This product is a custom-made helmet produced by Xyliton, a famous Finnish equipment manufacturer. It has all sorts of functions, but most importantly, it has been enchanted with a video-recording spell…”

Im Changsoo stared at everyone with his mouth hanging open, betrayed and utterly dumbfounded. Then he let out a long sigh.

“I’ll do it.”

“What did you say?”

“I said I’ll do everything you tell me to!”

That was the answer I had been waiting for.

I happily helped him back to his feet.

“Good choice, kid. We can discuss the damages at our leisure.”

“…This is driving me crazy. If my boomer finds out, I’m dead.”

“Would you rather die here?”

“You don’t want the four billion?[466]”

“You’ve got some nerve.”

Im Changsoo let out another deep sigh before speaking.

“May I ask one question?”

“One hundred million[467] per question.”

“…”

“I’m kidding. Go ahead.”

“What do you really do?”

Was he really that curious?

I let out a quiet laugh and answered him.

“Someone with two jobs.”

A Hunter and a Murim martial artist.

The only two-job combination in the world.

[466] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[467] One hundred million won is about $71,000 or €65,000.

Chapter 85

"Changsoo hyung[468], are you okay?"

"Are you hurt?"

At his team members' questions, Im Changsoo clenched his teeth.

"Shut up, you bastards. After everything I've done for you, you just stood there and watched?"

"No, it's just…"

"Things were a little complicated back there. I'm sorry."

"You disloyal bastards."

They weren't bound together by loyalty, but Im Changsoo had always thought he gave them what they were due and received what he was owed in return. Who had forced those training-camp washouts into the Guild, bought them cars, and given them spending money?

He had received their loyalty in exchange…but being abandoned at the most important moment felt like a stinging blow to the back of the head.

Fuck, what kind of bullshit is this?

Several billion won[469]? It was certainly a lot of money, but not more than Im Changsoo could afford. Selling one or two of the buildings in his name would be enough to cover it.

But he could never tolerate having his pride trampled.

That bastard deserves to be beaten to death.

Im Changsoo glared at one person's back, his eyes wide.

That bastard in the black leather armor—Jin Taekyung—was the root cause of everything.

I don't know where he came from or what he was doing before this…but I'll make him pay for this humiliation.

He still didn't know exactly who Taekyung was. The one thing he knew for certain was that Taekyung was no ordinary C-rank Hunter.

There wasn't a single C-rank Hunter in the world who could crush eight B-rank monsters in a head-on fight.

Why is he hiding his identity? Is he a fugitive? Or someone with a fraudulent registration? The moment we get out of this Gate, I'll dig up every last thing about him.

Just as Im Changsoo was quietly stoking his thirst for revenge—

Whoosh!

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[468] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[469] Several billion won is approximately $1.4–6.4 million or €1.3–5.8 million.

Jin Taekyung suddenly turned toward him and narrowed his eyes. The gaze of a predator staring down its prey made Im Changsoo's heart drop.

"Hey."

"Y-yes?"

"You were just cursing me in your head, weren't you?"

"N-no, I wasn't."

"Don't give me that. The stammering says it all. No wonder the back of my head has been prickling this whole time."

Im Changsoo recalled the words of his father, a Hunter and war hero from the Great Cataclysm era.

The more dangerous the situation, the more calmly you must respond.

"I really wasn't."

"My mind-reading technique says you're lying."

"Mind-reading? There's no such thing."

"There's magic, so why can't there be mind-reading? Let go of your hidebound thinking."

"Either way, I swear I wasn't."

"No, I swear you were. And you've got one coming too."

Bonk!

Tears sprang to Im Changsoo's eyes.

It was a sharp rap on the forehead. Even his father hadn't hit him since he turned twenty. Yet here he was, suffering this humiliation at the hands of someone barely his own age—and in front of his team members and several women, no less.

"Not bad. Feels just like hitting Hyuk Mujin. Anyway, watch yourself, okay?"

Im Changsoo had no idea who Hyuk Mujin was, but he lowered his head anyway.

"…Yes."

"But this damn labyrinth never ends. Hey, how much farther is it to the Boss Zone?"

"I don't know. It's a labyrinth."

"And no more monsters are coming out. I'm bored to death."

"…"

Of course they aren't! You beat down every single one you see!

Im Changsoo and his team hadn't even needed to step in. Those five were more than enough. No, Jin Taekyung alone was enough.

What a monster. Is he really an A-rank Hunter?

Taekyung alone seemed to have brought down more than thirty monsters. Just when he appeared to be tiring, he would suddenly start tearing through them again.

The raid is getting faster.

Normally, a raid slowed toward the end as fatigue accumulated.

But the raid was getting faster even though they were fighting the same monsters…

Is he getting stronger the whole time?

Im Changsoo desperately rejected the thought that had flashed through his mind.

What is he, a game character leveling up? How could that make any sense?

Getting hit on the forehead must have broken his brain.

"Hoo."

As Im Changsoo let out a deep sigh, his team members approached him hesitantly.

"Changsoo hyung[470]…"

"Oppa[471], are you okay? Oh no, you've got a bump on your forehead."

"I'm in a bad mood, so get lost. The moment you leave, you're all fired. Got it?"

No matter how badly his dignity had been crushed, even a tiger with its teeth pulled was still a tiger.

His team members swallowed nervously at Im Changsoo's threat.

I haven't even finished paying off my car.

Who'll take me if I leave Sangdong Guild?

My credit-card bill this month…

They had been able to live so comfortably thanks to Im Changsoo's support. They were all Hunters, so they wouldn't starve, but they couldn't expect the same treatment anywhere else.

"You think it ends with getting fired? Just wait. Wherever you go, I'll make sure to place a call in Sangdong Guild's name. You know this field is small, right?"

Their expressions changed completely at the threat that he would not only drive them out but ruin their futures as well.

"Changsoo hyung[472], that's going too far."

"Hyung[473]? I'm only your hyung[474] when it suits you?"

"Oppa[475], do you really have to take it that far?"

"That's why you bastards should've picked the right person to hitch your wagon to."

He wanted to slap every last one of them across the face, but he forced himself to hold back.

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[470] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[471] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.
[472] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[473] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[474] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[475] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.

If he raised his voice, there was no telling when Jin Taekyung might turn around again.

Fuck, how did I end up…

Too afraid of another rap on the forehead to even lose his temper properly. How pathetic could he get?

Im Changsoo spat on the floor and turned away.

That was when someone grabbed him.

"Changsoo hyung[476]. No, Team Leader Im, you can't do this."

"Please think it over one more time, oppa[477]. Okay?"

"Let go. I don't want to say it twice."

"This time, I mean it. I really will do anything you tell me. Okay?"

"…Anything I tell you?"

Im Changsoo stopped just as he was about to shake off his colleague's hand.

He glanced back. While he had been arguing with his Guild members, Jin Taekyung's group had pulled far ahead.

Even from that distance, Song Song's stunning figure from behind was impossible to miss.

Wait. Maybe there is a way.

To Im Changsoo, Jin Taekyung looked like a monster—but he seemed to have one weakness.

A woman named Song Song.

He was completely smitten earlier.

There was no need to be perceptive about it. Anyone could tell from a single glance that Jin Taekyung had feelings for Song Song.

She said she was a C-rank healer, right?

Subduing a healer would be easier than wringing a chicken's neck. If the woman he liked were taken hostage, Jin Taekyung wouldn't be able to move so freely.

Then it's over.

Apart from Taekyung, the other three weren't much of a concern.

The old man who was supposedly their Guild Master was a B-rank Hunter, but he was a mage, so close combat would be his weakness. The middle-aged E-rank tank wasn't even worth discussing.

The only person who bothered Im Changsoo a little was Choi Minwoo. That guy…

"Can I trust what you just said?"

"Of course."

"Just trust us."

---

[476] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[477] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.

"Oppa[478], why don't you trust people at all? Are we really only this close?"

Im Changsoo had a raid team made up of four B-rank Hunters and five C-rank Hunters who would obey his commands. He had trained every one of them to eat only from his hand.

"Fine. Then listen carefully to what I'm about to say…"

After a short and simple explanation, the team members couldn't hide their nervousness.

"Will it work?"

"It does seem possible."

"Oppa[479], you're not suggesting what I think you are, right? If you mean killing someone, I don't know if I can do that."

"Didn't you just say you'd do anything I told you?"

"Even so, that's a little…"

"Forget it. I'd like to, but I'm not reckless enough to go that far. First, we take the camera. Then we put that son of a bitch through a humiliation he'll never live down."

"Whew. That's a relief. Then I'm definitely on your side, oppa[480]."

"Do it right. You know what happens if anyone hesitates this time or holds back even a little, right?"

"Of course."

"Just trust us, Team Leader. No, hyungnim[481]. Hehe."

A sinister smile spread across Im Changsoo's lips.

If he trampled on my pride, he has to pay the price.

In the Boss Zone ahead, he would make Jin Taekyung understand exactly who he had dared to cross.

There was even a monster there capable of standing against him.

The Minotaur Great Warrior.

The boss monster of **The Minotaur's Labyrinth**.

Despite being only a B-rank monster, it was a monstrous creature whose physical abilities rivaled those of an A-rank.

Once the Great Warrior wears him down, we'll make our move.

Set a barbarian against a barbarian.

Defeat a monster with a monster.

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[478] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.
[479] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.
[480] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.
[481] *Hyungnim* is a more respectful form of *hyung*.

The moment both sides were exhausted would be their chance. In one stroke, he could recover both the money he was about to lose for nothing and the pride that had been dragged through the dirt.

“Hey, hurry up! It’s the Boss Zone!”

Jin Taekyung’s shout rang out the next moment.

Im Changsoo smiled broadly.

“Yes! Coming!”

His steps toward the Boss Zone were remarkably light.

“One Annihilation.”

Kraaaaaash!

The sound of the sky splitting erupted from the tip of my spear. A white vortex that tore apart and devoured everything it touched slammed into the Great Warrior’s muscular chest.

—Moo?

Crack-crack-crack!

There was no need to check whether it was alive or dead.

The moment I pulled my spear from its chest, the System notification rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Defeated Lv. 70 Minotaur Great Warrior!
Level Up!
Quest, B-rank Gate Clear, completed!
Calculating your contribution... Complete!
The Quest Success Reward has been deposited into your Inventory!

“Whew.”

The last one should always end with one big hit.

My body was incredibly tired, though.

I shook the blood from my spear and turned around.

“Let’s collect the byproducts and get out of here. I’m starving to dea—why are you all looking at me like that?”

Im Kkeokjeong spoke for everyone.

“You really have to ask?”

He looked back and forth between the boss monster’s corpse and me.

His eyes demanded some kind of explanation for how I had finished off a B-rank boss monster with a single blow.

"Hmm. Let's just say I got lucky."

"Lucky?"

"Yes. Lucky."

It really was because I had been lucky.

Lucky that I had lived in a goshiwon.[482] Lucky that a capsule had been discarded in front of it.

All of it.

"Good grief. I'm too dumbfounded to speak. Fine."

The others reacted much the same way as Im Kkeokjeong. Even Team Leader Choi, who had already been on a raid with me, looked stunned.

"I didn't realize you were this capable."

"If you know now, that's enough."

"Could we discuss this?"

"Of course."

Not now. Later.

I still had something more important to take care of.

With my most charming smile, I approached one person.

"Miss Song, could I ask you for a heal—what are you guys doing over there?"

"Ah."

"What are you doing? Why are you here?"

"We're just…just standing here."

"I-I just think she's so beautiful."

The Sangdong Guild members clustered around Song Song jumped in surprise and began blurting out whatever came to mind.

What's with these guys?

I only meant that they should get lost because they were getting in the way between me and Miss Song.

Do I really look that scary?

"Where's Im Changsoo?"

At a single word from me, the Sangdong Guild members split apart like the Red Sea.

Im Changsoo answered from behind them, his face white as a sheet.

"I'm here."

"What's wrong with your face? Are you sick?"

[482] A *goshiwon* is a building of very small, inexpensive rooms, often used by students and people on tight budgets.

“I-I think I’m coming down with something.”

“Tsk, tsk. Take a potion, you idiot. Your family’s rich.”

“…”

“Anyway, hurry up and collect the byproducts. Let’s go. I’m tired.”

“Yes, yessir.”

Once Im Changsoo disappeared with the nuisances, the moment I had been waiting for finally arrived.

I flashed Song Song a bright smile.

“You’re hungry, right? How about steak at a nice restaurant for dinner?”

Song Song smiled back at me.

“I’m sorry, but I’m a vegetarian.”

“That’s strange. You seemed to eat meat just fine yesterday. How about a salad bar?”

“I’m a carnivore.”

“…”

I got rejected, right?

Chapter 86

“Oh, thank you for your hard work.”

The government official in charge came rushing out to greet us.

Well, more accurately, he came to greet Im Changsoo.

After meticulously checking all the byproducts and Magic Gems we had brought, he made a fuss.

“Wow, that’s an incredible haul. You must’ve wiped out every Minotaur in the labyrinth.”

“…”

Im Changsoo’s face was pale. He only nodded without answering, making the official glance around uneasily.

“Team Leader, are you feeling unwell?”

Since when did government officials start worrying about Hunters’ health?

Before he could say anything unnecessary, I jabbed Im Changsoo in the ribs.

“You have to answer him. Chang. Soo.”

“Um… No, I’m fine.”

“Ah, that’s a relief, then.”

Maybe he had sensed the strange atmosphere. The official gave me a suspicious look, but that was as far as it went.

“How would you like to handle the byproducts? As you know, there are two methods.”

As the official said, there were two ways to sell byproducts.

Private sales and consignment sales. With the former, the owner handled the transaction personally. With the latter, the goods were entrusted to the Administration—a government agency—to be sold.

Each method has its pros and cons.

Rare items were more profitable to sell privately. For everything else, handing them over to a government agency saved a lot of trouble. It was like the difference between a luxury auction and a market auction.

“What should we do?”

At Im Changsoo’s question, Butler Kim stepped forward. He hadn’t once taken the lead during this Gate raid, but he was still a veteran Hunter. When it came to this sort of thing, he probably knew more than anyone else here.

“We’ll sell them to the Administration.”

They said no part of a cow went to waste. The same was true of Minotaurs.

Their hides were used to make Equipment, their bones were simmered into restorative food, and their horns were popular collector’s items among enthusiasts.

"You've made the right choice."

The government official began calculating the value of the byproducts with an expression of pure delight. The Administration was the one buying them, so the reason he was so happy was obvious.

He must be getting a little something off the top.

Still, whatever the official skimmed off wasn't my concern.

The cut I was getting today was much bigger.

Tap, tap.

"What about the amount you promised?"

Im Changsoo answered with a rigid expression.

"I-I'll pay it."

"By when?"

"I'll send it by tomorrow."

Four billion won[483] by tomorrow? The son of a rich family certainly didn't mess around. I smiled broadly and handed him a slip of paper.

"Well, that works for me. Here's my account number. Treasure it like a family heirloom, then send the money tomorrow. It won't be funny if you claim you lost it later. Got it?"

"…Yes, sir."

That should be enough, right? I said goodbye by giving Im Changsoo a light pat on the back.

As I watched with satisfaction as he staggered away, Im Kkeokjeong asked me,

"Do you think that punk will actually pay?"

"And if he doesn't?"

"Well, you know… things could get a little messy. Sangdong Guild is a mid-tier Guild with some serious influence around here. If he just tells you to do your worst and refuses to pay…"

"Come on, we have video evidence. Surely he wouldn't."

"Evidence can be destroyed. More importantly, I've heard a few things."

"Like what?"

Now that he had put it that way, I was starting to get a little worried.

Kkeokjeong glanced around, checking everyone's reactions, then leaned in and whispered,

"You know who the Sangdong Guild Master is, right?"

"Yes. Though today was the first time I heard his name."

Im Chunsoo. For some reason, the name brought to mind a middle-aged man with a bulging beer belly, but the reality was the exact opposite.

[483] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

“He’s an A-rank Hunter who distinguished himself during the Great Cataclysm. What do people call him again? Fro… Fro… It’s suddenly slipping my mind.”

“Frozen.”

“Ah, right. Frozen. A mage specializing in ice magic.”

Famous Hunters were often given epithets that suited their abilities.

The same was true of Im Chunsoo. An A-rank Hunter, he was a mage who had played a major role in the Great Cataclysm, and his particular skill with ice magic had earned him the epithet Frozen.

“When it comes to ice magic, that man is one of the top five in Korea. He used that Fame to build Sangdong Guild into what it is today.”

When the brutal Great Cataclysm finally came to an end, the first-generation Hunters faced a choice.

Retire, or remain active.

Im Chunsoo chose the latter and founded Sangdong Guild.

“That’s impressive. His son doesn’t seem like much.”

Even among A-rank Hunters, it was rare for someone to survive the Great Cataclysm with nothing but their bare fists and gain both wealth and fame. Im Chunsoo’s present was the future many Hunters dreamed of.

“Impressive? Bloodlines certainly are.”

Kkeokjeong jerked his chin toward Im Changsoo’s retreating back.

“Don’t forget whose blood that punk inherited.”

“What do you mean…?”

“I’m not bragging, but I’ve been in this business for over twenty years. Sangdong Guild was founded when I was still a complete rookie.”

“And?”

“Bucheon was just as fiercely competitive between Guilds back then as it is now. There was no room for a new Guild to squeeze in.”

“But Im Chunsoo broke through anyway?”

“That’s right. That’s why he’s a frightening man.”

“Hmm.”

Did that really follow?

Competition between Guilds was nothing new, and in a meritocracy, it was only natural for the capable to survive.

“A man like him would have had excellent abilities as a Hunter and plenty of Fame. He must have had powerful connections, too.”

“Do you think the other Guild Masters didn’t?”

“What?”

"They might have had slightly less Fame than Im Chunsoo, but every one of them had been a war hero. They had entered the market several years before Sangdong Guild and occupied a substantial number of Gates."

Kkeokjeong continued in a low voice.

"It was a time when all kinds of illegal activity ran rampant because the system hadn't been fully established yet. The only reason Sangdong Guild exists today is that Im Chunsoo crushed every one of his competitors. He's no pushover."

A thought suddenly flashed through my mind.

What would happen if Im Chunsoo found out about what had happened today? How would he react to hearing that his only son had been utterly humiliated?

This could get complicated.

When it came to Korea, you couldn't leave out school ties, hometown ties, or blood ties.

Sangdong Guild had held its ground for twenty years. If it was a local power, our Guild was practically a newborn.

If Sangdong Guild came at us in earnest, they'd tear up our birth certificate before we even got started.

"Is the Sangdong Guild Master good-natured, at least?"

"I wouldn't know. I've only heard rumors."

"At least tell me what you've heard."

After thinking for a moment, Kkeokjeong answered,

"Seeing Im Changsoo today reminded me of an old saying: a tiger father and a dog son."

"A great father and a worthless son? That's still a compliment, isn't it? Is he someone you can reason with?"

"No. Interpret it literally."

"…A tiger for a father and a dog for a son?"

"If Changsoo's personality is that of a son of a bitch, then Im Chunsoo is a tiger. I hear his temper is absolutely fucking terrible."

"…"

"I've also heard he mellowed with age, but can a person's temper really change that easily?"

For fuck's sake.

The more I heard, the colder my spine felt. I had the distinct feeling that something was about to go horribly wrong.

Damn it. I shouldn't have made that bet.

My excitement at the thought of receiving several billion won[484] had lasted only a moment. Now I felt uneasy, like I'd taken a huge dump and forgotten to wipe.

[484] Several billion won is roughly $1.4–6.4 million or €1.3–5.8 million.

I could deal with whatever happened to me, but I absolutely refused to let the other Guild members get hurt.

"Taekyung, don't worry about it too much. I only brought it up just in case."

"I didn't just cause trouble, did I?"

"It'll be fine. Team Leader Choi thought it sounded fun and joined the bet, too."

"Oh, right."

"Exactly. And look at the way Im Changsoo acted. If I were his father, I would've beaten him half to death. I'd be too embarrassed to tell anyone what happened."

He had a point. What could possibly happen?

Hearing that made me feel considerably lighter. I even found myself smiling.

"Thanks, Kkeokjeong ajusshi[485]. No, hyungnim[486]."

"Then buy me some beef to celebrate becoming a rich man. Wait, no. You should eat it with Miss Song, not me."

"…Ah."

He was driving a nail straight through my heart.

As Im Kkeokjeong killed me with words for the second time, I swallowed my tears.

"What brings you here?"

The speaker was a man with a distinctive appearance.

He was nearing fifty, but his skin was taut and his black hair bristled like wire. His large, piercing eyes alone were enough to make anyone's knees go weak.

What the hell is with that look in his eyes…?

The manager of a K Bank branch was no exception. He had already met the man several times, but he was an ordinary person, while the other man was an A-rank Hunter—a living witness who had endured the Great Cataclysm with his entire body.

His tongue tied itself in knots, and cold sweat trickled down his back.

"Well…"

"If you came to waste my valuable time, go back. Otherwise, speak now."

The words were sharp, but his tone was fairly gentle.

The manager had heard the rumor that Im Chunsoo was trying to mellow his temper with age. Apparently, it hadn't been a complete waste of effort.

Damn it.

The branch manager squeezed his eyes shut and blurted it out.

"I'm sorry, Guild Master. I've come regarding your son."

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[485] *Ajusshi* is a familiar way to address a middle-aged man.

[486] *Hyungnim* is a respectful form of "older brother" used by a man addressing an older man.

At the mention of his son, Sangdong Guild Master Im Chunsoo's eyebrow twitched.

"Changsoo? What about him?"

"Some time ago, you asked me to let you know whenever your son used any of the bank's services…"

Im Chunsoo nodded as if he understood where this was going.

"What is it this time? Did he steal my seal[487]? Or take out a secured loan?"

"He transferred a considerable amount of money all at once."

"He must be fooling around with women again. Obviously. How much?"

"Four billion won[488] to each of two accounts. Eight billion won[489] in total."

"How much?"

"Eight billion… Hup."

The branch manager hurriedly swallowed his breath. He had just watched the window behind Im Chunsoo rapidly freeze over.

Hiss.

It was late summer outside, but cold and frost now ruled the office.

Im Chunsoo motioned to the trembling branch manager.

"Anything else?"

"I-I brought the relevant documents."

With shaking hands, the branch manager placed a stack of papers on the desk.

"Good. You may leave."

"I-I'll see you next time."

After the branch manager fled the room, Im Chunsoo picked up the receiver. The phone had a cold-resistance function, so it transmitted the signal quickly without any problems.

Beep, beep. Click.

"—Yes, Guild Master. Team One's Leader speaking."

"Bring that bastard here immediately."

"—…Do you mean Team Leader Im Changsoo?"

"Team Leader, my ass. He's fired as of today. Bring that bastard here now!"

Bang!

The receiver's life ended there. It shattered into hundreds of icy fragments that covered the desk.

"What a pathetic fool. Even after I warned him…"

Im Chunsoo glared coldly at the wrecked office, then his gaze stopped on one spot.

The stack of papers left behind by the K Bank branch manager.

---

[487] A personal seal can be used in Korea to authenticate official documents and financial transactions.

[488] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[489] Eight billion won is about $5.7 million or €5.2 million.

There was no doubt that the documents contained the whereabouts of eight billion won[490].

You stupid bastard. Which bitch did you get taken in by this time?

He read through the papers, turning them one page at a time, for a little over ten minutes.

When Im Chunsoo closed the final page, the door flew open with the sound of someone being dragged along.

“Team Leader Im Changsoo. I brought him here.”

An affable-looking middle-aged man stood there.

Clutched firmly in his grasp was a young man.

“F-Father!”

“My proud son is here.”

At his son’s appearance, the father extended a hand.

Of course, it was not a gesture of forgiveness.

Crackle, crackle, crackle.

Cold surged from Im Chunsoo’s grasp. It changed from gas to liquid, then from liquid to solid, completing its transformation into an ice club as hard as steel.

“I have a lot to ask you, but first, you’re getting hit.”

“Father!”

“Shut up, you little shit!”

The middle-aged man who had brought Im Changsoo—the Team Leader of Sangdong Guild’s Team One—quietly closed the door.

The room would be off-limits for the next half day.

[490] Eight billion won is about $5.7 million or €5.2 million.

Chapter 87

"Achoo!"

Patter-patter!

Jinho hyung[491] calmly wiped the ramen and grains of rice from his face with a wet tissue.

"If you don't like it, say so. Use your words."

"It's not like that. It just came out of nowhere."

"Don't make excuses. You only look more pathetic."

But I was telling the truth. Instead of answering, I rubbed my nose.

Is someone badmouthing me?

Come to think of it, there is one guy with good reason to.

If it was Im Changsoo, he had more than enough motive. Still, he was the Santa Claus who had given me four billion won,[492] so I was happy to take a few insults.

I wasn't sure he would, but the bastard actually kept his promise.

I remembered the text message I had received that morning. The banking app installed on my smartphone notified me of every deposit and withdrawal without exception.

> 4,000,000,000 won[493] has been deposited into Jin Taekyung's account, 110--.

The only minor mishap was that Jinho hyung[494] had discovered it before I did. Leaving my smartphone in the room when I went to take a shower had been a mistake.

"You've got plenty of money, and you're eating ramen? Ramen?"

"You sure talk a lot. I put beef in it. Don't you like beef ramen?"

"That's not what I mean, you punk."

Bang!

Jinho hyung[495] roughly set down his utensils.

Of course, he hadn't done it to make a point. He was just full.

"I mean, you've got four billion won[496] in your bank account, so why are you eating ramen in a goshiwon?[497]"

"What's it to you? I'll do what I want."

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[491] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.
[492] Four billion Korean won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million at the project conversion rates.
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[494] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.
[495] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.
[496] Four billion Korean won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million at the project conversion rates.
[497] A *goshiwon* is a tiny, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often with shared facilities.

"…Fair enough."

"And the money only came in an hour ago, all right? I don't know what to do with it either, so be quiet and let me think."

I was pretending to be fine, but I had been dazed for a while now. I had worked myself to the bone like a worker ant, but there had always been somewhere the money needed to go.

Then a fortune had dropped out of the sky.

Four billion won[498] was enough to do a lot of things. Naturally, it gave me a lot to think about.

"What are you thinking so hard about? There must have been something you wanted to do first as soon as you got money."

The first thing I wanted to do…

There is one thing.

Slurp.

I sucked down the last strand of noodles and rose from my seat.

Before leaving the room, I made sure to give Jinho hyung[499] one last parting remark.

"Thanks."

"Don't mention it."

"Don't forget to wash the pot. I'm off."

"Hey! Hey!"

"Huh?"

Hayeon's eyes went round when she saw me outside the front door.

"So it really is you. I saw you on the intercom and thought, no way."

"…If it wasn't really me, what would I be?"

"Hmm. Computer graphics?"

"Is that any way to talk to your older brother after not seeing him for so long?"

"What are you talking about? You were here the day before yesterday."

Oh, right. Hardly any time had passed in the real world.

The time difference was so large that even I got confused sometimes. I took off my shoes and asked, "What were you doing?"

"Studying."

"Come to think of it, what about school? It's a weekday."

Hayeon answered in a nasal voice.

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[498] Four billion Korean won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million at the project conversion rates.

[499] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

"They said my fever was thirty-nine degrees Celsius.[500] I stuck it out until second period, then left early. Summer vacation starts tomorrow anyway, and we've been doing nothing but self-study lately."

"You're already on vacation? No, wait. You left school early because you were sick, and you're studying?"

Somehow, she seemed even more impressive than a Peak master. Whenever I got really sick at school, my illness mysteriously vanished the moment I left early and got home.

She had a raging fever, yet she was still studying. Did we really have different DNA?

"There is no end to learning."

Leaving Hayeon, who sounded like a school disciplinarian, behind, I entered the living room. Apart from the two of us, there wasn't a sign of anyone else in the house.

"Where's Mom?"

"The bank."

"You had that answer ready."

"It's true."

"Did Mom tell you to say that?"

"Huh? Tell me to say what?"

I wondered who she took after. Her acting was so natural that if I hadn't already known the truth, I would have fallen for it completely.

I should've told Mom sooner.

A bitter smile escaped me before I could stop it. As I turned back toward the entrance, Hayeon grabbed me.

"Where are you going?"

"To find Mom."

"There are tons of banks around here. I'll make you something to eat, so stay here. She'll be home soon."

"It's fine. I'm not going to the bank."

"What?"

"The restaurant at the intersection in front of the supermarket. Right?"

The strength slowly drained from Hayeon's hand.

"…You knew?"

"Yeah. For a long time."

"Mom asked me to keep it a secret."

"I know that too."

[500] Thirty-nine degrees Celsius is about 102 degrees Fahrenheit.

"Oppa,[501] can't you stay?"

It was one of Hayeon's longtime habits. Whenever she had an important favor to ask, she always put *oppa*[502] first.

"I'll be back."

I ruffled Hayeon's hair and left the house.

As the elevator carried me down, I quietly thought about her warmth still lingering in my hand—and why she was studying even while her forehead was burning up.

A person had only one name on their resident registration card, but they went by many names over the course of their life. Kim Jeonghee, who had turned exactly fifty that year, was no different.

"Ajumma,[503] two more servings of pork belly over here."

"Yes, just a moment."

The name she was called most often these days was *ajumma*.[504] Before that, it had been "Hayeon's mom." Before that, "Taekyung's mom." Once the children had grown up and work had become busy, she had stopped hearing those names.

The one person who had called her by her real name had passed away long ago.

"Jeonghee-ssi."[505]

She had met him when she was twenty-two. He had been kind and affectionate. Amid the chaos of the Great Cataclysm, a man and a woman met in a shelter and fell in love at once.

Their marriage had been a happy one. Even as the years passed, he continued to call her by name.

"Jeonghee."

Sometimes, embarrassed to hear him call her by name in front of other people, she had asked him about it.

"Why do you only call me Jeonghee? Other husbands call their wives 'so-and-so's mom,' 'honey,' or 'the missus.' That's what everyone else does."

"You don't like it?"

"No, it's not that. I was just curious. We're getting older too, you know."

"What does age have to do with it? I call you Jeonghee because I love Jeonghee more than I love Taekyung's mom."

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[501] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[502] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[503] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

[504] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

[505] *-Ssi* is a polite Korean suffix attached to a person's name.

“Why are you acting like this in front of the kids?”

“Huh? Mom’s cheeks are red. Mom, do you and Dad wrestle in the mornings too? You do it every night.”

“…Taekyung, starting today, go to bed early.”

Their parting came sooner than expected. A Gate opened in the middle of downtown without warning, and the two children lost their father while she lost her husband—the only person who had called her by name.

“Ajumma![506]”

Kim Jeonghee jolted back to reality. A middle-aged woman with permed hair and flashy earrings was glaring at her.

“Oh, yes, ma’am.”

“What were you doing that you couldn’t even hear me calling you?”

“I’m sorry.”

“What about the grill plates? Are you done washing them?”

“Well, the thing is…”

Her hands had stopped while she was lost in thought. The owner checked the sink and glared at her.

“Ajumma,[507] is this how you’re going to work?”

“…”

“Honestly. If you’re going to work like this, I might as well do it myself. Why would I pay good money to hire you? Am I wrong?”

Kim Jeonghee bowed her head while the other kitchen workers kept working, pretending not to hear the owner.

Good money, my ass. She works us at minimum wage during the busiest hours.

She’s old enough to know better. She knows perfectly well that no amount of caked-on makeup and dressing up will make her a match for Jeonghee ajumma,[508] so she’s taking it out on her.

She should watch the counter properly herself in the first place. How many orders did Jeonghee take while she was off having fun?

They had plenty to say, but they could only keep it to themselves. The kitchen ajumma[509] who had finally lost her patience and stood up for Kim Jeonghee had been fired the previous week.

“How am I supposed to feel comfortable leaving this place in your hands?”

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[506] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

[507] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

[508] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

[509] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

"…I'm sorry."

"I heard your son is a Hunter. He should be making decent money, so why don't you just stay home and cook? Why come all the way here and be a nuisance to someone else's business? Ah, is his income not very good because he's an F-rank Hunter?"

The moment a sneer appeared at the corners of the owner's mouth, Kim Jeonghee slowly raised her bowed head.

"Boss. You've gone too far."

"What?"

"I said you went too far."

"Are you saying I said something wrong?"

"Yes."

The unfamiliar sensation left the owner speechless. Kim Jeonghee had always been quiet and gentle, but now her eyes had sunk into a deep stare.

"Please apologize for what you just said."

"A-apologize?"

"Right here. Right now."

"O-oh my. Fine, then. What part of what I said was wrong? Your son really is an F-rank Hunter!"

"Is his rank really that important?"

"Of course it is. What good is an F-rank Hunter? You have to be at least my son's caliber to make good money and have women lining up for you. This shop, too…"

"Your son, the D-rank Hunter, opened it for you. I know. I've heard it dozens—no, hundreds—of times."

The employees, who had pricked up their ears, unconsciously nodded.

The owner's bragging about her son was a familiar routine they heard several times a day.

How much he made, how big his house was, what kind of car he drove, and how filial he was—so filial that he had even opened a shop for his mother to have something to do. She had repeated it so often that even the regular customers were sick of hearing it.

"Then you know all about it. I run this place as a hobby, but you're different, aren't you? You're working in the kitchen because your son doesn't make enough money, aren't you?"

"No. That's not why."

Kim Jeonghee continued calmly.

"Our Taekyung grew up right. He never once caused his parents any trouble, even when he was little. He's still working hard for his family. Money? He earns more than enough."

"That's all an excuse."

"An excuse? This is money my child earned by risking his life. How could I, as his parent, accept it and spend it?"

"Ajumma,[510] was that meant for me to hear?"

"That depends on how you choose to take it. And since we're on the subject, when does that amazing son of yours ever show his face?"

"Wh-what?"

"I've worked here for over a year, but that devoted son of yours hasn't visited even once. He does at least call you, doesn't he?"

The kitchen fell deathly silent. The owner's face turned bright red, and her eyes bulged.

"Where does a bitch with such a pathetic son get off—"

The employees knew what was coming next. Along with the owner's machine-gun burst of abuse, the word "fired" was bound to come flying out.

But none of them could have predicted Kim Jeonghee's reaction.

"Watch your mouth, you goddamn bitch."

"…!"

"…!"

It was as if a bomb had gone off.

A deathly silence descended as everyone's eyes trembled with disbelief. Every person in the kitchen wondered if they had heard correctly.

What did I just hear?

Did Jeonghee ajumma[511] just swear? My God.

Kim Jeonghee had always been gentle and quick to smile. Even when the owner picked fights with her day after day, she had bowed her head without a single word of complaint.

Now she glared at the owner with eyes as cold as ice.

"W-what did you say? What did you just call me?"

"I called you a goddamn bitch, you fucking bitch."

"F-fucking bitch?!"

Before the shock had even faded, a second bomb went off. The owner's shriek rang all the way out into the dining area.

"Did someone just swear?"

"You heard that too? I think someone just called somebody a fucking bitch."

"What the hell? Are the employees fighting?"

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[510] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

[511] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman, commonly used to address service workers.

The murmuring grew louder. Customers and employees alike turned their attention toward the kitchen.

That was when it happened.

Thud. Thud.

A large young man with his cap pulled low. No one had noticed when he entered, or how long he had been standing there. Not until he started walking toward the kitchen.

“S-sir. I’ll take your order…”

The young man smiled faintly at the male employee who hurried to block his path.

“It’s all right. I’m not here to order.”

“No, but still, right now…”

“Excuse me.”

Tap.

It was only a gentle push, but the burly employee staggered and fell. Without hesitation, the young man shoved the half-open kitchen door wide.

And then…

“Mom.”

He came face-to-face with the person he loved most in the world.

Chapter 88

"Son?"

Her eyes widened when she saw me.

She wore an apron printed with the restaurant's name and rubber gloves smeared with grease.

My mother.

Her surprise quickly turned to bewilderment.

"Ta-Taekyung, what are you doing here?"

I flashed my flustered mother a broad grin. Just then, a shrill voice pierced my ear.

"So you're Kim ajumma's[512] son?"

A middle-aged woman looked me over warily.

There was no need to ask who she was or what she did. I already knew.

"Hello. My name is Jin Taekyung."

"Huh? Ahem. Yes."

The owner gave an unnecessary cough after seeing me bow politely from the waist.

"But what brings you here all of a sudden?"

I answered with a pleasant smile.

"Does a son need a reason to visit his mother?"

"A reason?"

The owner narrowed her eyes.

"Maybe it's because you're young, but you're awfully thoughtless. If someone showed up out of the blue like this, how do you think I'd feel as the owner?"

"Hmm. I suppose you'd be upset."

"Exactly!"

"It's lunchtime, the restaurant is packed, and everyone in the kitchen and dining area is so busy they can barely see straight."

"…That's right."

"And then an employee's son suddenly shows up without saying a word? From your perspective, Boss, I can understand why you'd be upset. Completely."

"Y-you do understand."

What the hell is with this kid?

That was probably exactly what the owner was thinking.

Ignoring her confused reaction, I pulled my mother by the arm.

"In that case, we'll be going now. Mom, go change so we can leave."

---

[512] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman.

“What?”

“S-son?”

The two of them stared at me in bewilderment.

I asked with an innocent expression,

“Why?”

“What do you mean, why? Why?!”

“Is there some kind of problem?”

“You little punk, are you making fun of an adult? Did you already forget everything you just said?”

“Oh, you mean when I said you might be upset if someone came by while you were busy?”

“Yes! You said yourself that I might be upset, and now you’ve forgotten already? Are you making fun of me right now?!”

“Oh, come on. I’m not making fun of you.”

“Then what is this?”

“I meant every word. From your perspective, Boss, you have every right to feel that way. But…”

I continued with a bright smile.

“My mother isn’t your employee anymore.”

“What?”

“Is that hard to understand? She’s quitting. Starting right now.”

A heavy silence descended.

My mother stared blankly at me, while the owner’s face turned dark red before she shrieked.

“Who said you could do that?!”

“We did.”

“You think I’ll just let you take her away?”

“What happens if you don’t?”

“Y-you!”

“Th-three, three! F-four, four!”

That was as far as the owner’s patience went.

“Hey, you fucking son of a bitch!”

The hand she raised along with her vicious curse never reached its target.

Grab!

Someone caught the owner’s wrist in a single motion and glared at her.

My mother spat the words out, radiating an aura fierce enough to make even a First Rate master flinch.

“Whose son do you think you’re laying a hand on, you fucking bitch?”

Good Lord.

I had heard her swear once earlier in the dining area, but this was the first time in my life I had seen my mother curse like this. She never even spoke ill of other people in front of her children, and yet…

“And who are you calling a son of a bitch? Your son is the son of a bitch, you pig!”

“You’ve been getting on my nerves from the start! Hey!”

The owner charged at my mother, but I stepped between them.

I was big enough to stand out wherever I went. Simply standing between the two middle-aged women was more than enough.

“Now, now. Calm down. Please calm down.”

“Move! Are you going to move or not? Do you think you’ll get away with this?”

“Yes. I think we’ll live quite comfortably.”

“Gaaaah!”

The owner’s eyes rolled back as she began wildly swinging her arms with a scream.

Of course, none of her attacks posed the slightest threat to me.

It’s embarrassing to even call that an attack.

Compared to the enemies I had faced inside Gates and in the Murim, it was no more dangerous than a fly beating its wings. Now that my bones and muscles, Sinews and Meridians, and Toughness had all improved dramatically, even a punch from an ordinary adult man would only tickle.

“Please stop. You look like you’re having a really hard time.”

As expected, the owner’s struggle ended quickly.

She was in her fifties and morbidly obese. Her body clearly had its limits.

“Huff, huff! You Hunter bastard, are you bullying a civilian?”

That she could come out with a line like that—I had to marvel at how the owner’s brain worked.

“Me? Bullying you?”

“Can’t you see I’m hurt? My fingernail broke, and it’s bleeding!”

“You hurt yourself hitting me. I’ve just been standing here, so why are you trembling all by yourself?”

“Whatever!”

This was a bumper crop of bullshit.

I glanced around. The kitchen staff and the customers in the dining area were all watching the owner’s stand-up routine with disgusted expressions.

“If you can’t accept what happened, call the police. There must be about fifty witnesses here, so that works out nicely.”

“…”

"Not going to call? Since you were injured and bled because of a Hunter, you should go to the police station, give a statement, file a complaint, and hire a lawyer. You'll be busy starting tomorrow."

I had intended to tease her a little longer, but the more we talked, the more I felt I was wasting my time. I clicked my tongue.

"What are you, the mayor? You're only the owner. Don't make everyone around you miserable, and try to have a better attitude. We're leaving."

I was about to turn away when the corners of the owner's mouth twisted with resentment.

"You live in Bucheon, don't you?"

"So?"

"Which Guild in Bucheon are you with?"

"Would you know it if I told you?"

"My son would. Our Minsu is a Hunter in Bucheon, too."

"Oh, really?"

"I hear Hunters all know one another after only a degree or two. I wonder how long you'll last if you get a bad reputation in that line of work."

"I have a reputation for being hardworking and skilled, so I'll be around for a long time. Happy?"

"Do you know Kim Minsu? My son must be famous in Bucheon."

Kim Minsu?

Sure. Over the past seven years, I had probably crossed paths with more than thirty people named Minsu.

I answered indifferently.

"Do you know Seong Jinho? He's the most famous person in our goshiwon.[513]"

"Pfft, a goshiwon? I suppose that's the level you'd expect from an F-rank Hunter. Is your income really that bad?"

"It's kind of you to worry, but I make a decent living. I made four billion won[514] just yesterday."

"How much?"

"Four billion won.[515]"

I hadn't wanted to boast about money like a child, but she just had to tug on a sleeping lion's nose hairs.

There was one thing I had forgotten, though.

People always judged everything according to their own common sense.

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[513] A *goshiwon* is a small, inexpensive room for rent, often with shared facilities.

[514] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[515] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

"Four billion won?[516] An F-rank Hunter made that much?"

"Obviously, he's bluffing. A Hunter I know said an F-rank Hunter has to work like hell to make even a hundred million won.[517] And didn't you hear him? He said he made four billion won[518] in a single day, not in a year. It's not like he won the lottery. Does that make any sense?"

"Geez, I almost thought he was telling the truth."

The customers in the dining area and even the kitchen staff, who had quietly seemed to be rooting for me, began looking at me doubtfully.

Well, even I had to admit it sounded absurd.

"Son, is that true?"

My mother's eyes went round.

The owner snorted.

"As if it's true. Even my Minsu can't make that much."

"I've been wondering. What rank is this famous Minsu of yours? A-rank?"

"He's a D-rank Hunter."

"…"

"What? Are you stunned because it's so high?"

"No, well… I'll admit I'm a little surprised."

She had sounded so confident that I thought her son was at least Monkey D. Minsu.[519]

Where is there a famous D-rank Hunter in Bucheon?

Perhaps she mistook my momentary silence for shock. The owner let out a series of derisive chuckles.

"You have to be a D-rank Hunter like my son to get respect wherever you go. An F-rank Hunter must be too embarrassed to even admit what he does for a living."

"I wasn't that embarrassed. I spoke just fine."

"You still get looked down on. Among Hunters, rank is everything."

"Ah, yes. Rank is everything."

"If I make one phone call, Minsu will…"

"Yes, yes."

As I answered halfheartedly and rummaged through my pocket, the owner raised her eyebrows.

"An adult is talking to you. Do you want my Minsu to teach you a lesson?"

"I'm just looking for something. Ah, here it is."

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[516] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[517] One hundred million won is about $71,000 or €65,000.

[518] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[519] Monkey D. Luffy is the protagonist of the Japanese manga *One Piece*. Taekyung substitutes Minsu's name for Luffy's.

"What is that?"

"If you're curious, take a look."

I had so many point cards and discount coupons in my wallet that finding anything was a chore. When the owner examined the thin silver card I handed her, her mouth fell open.

"…C-rank Hunter?"

"Personally, I think rank is everything for Hunters. What do you think, Boss?"

"N-no way. I heard you were F-rank…"

"I was F-rank. I'm C-rank now. You're pretty slow about updating your information."

"I-isn't this fake? The color is completely different from my Minsu's license!"

"His license is brass-colored, right?"

"…"

"I used one of those myself in the past. Lower-rank Hunters have brass-colored licenses, while mid-rank Hunters have silver ones. You didn't know that?"

Suppressed laughter erupted from all around us.

The atmosphere had flipped in an instant.

My mother slipped her arm through mine with a proud smile, while the owner's face turned bright red and she began making excuses.

"D-does a Hunter's rank really matter? C-rank and D-rank are only one step apart. They're practically the same."

Was that supposed to be an argument or a fart?

All I could do was laugh hollowly at her absurd struggle.

"That's not something a person who looked down on someone for their Hunter rank should be saying."

"Is a person's title all that matters? The company they work for matters more. People respect an Assistant Manager at a major corporation more than a section manager at a small company. Am I wrong?"

"I don't know about that, but the customers here don't seem to agree with you."

I gestured toward the customers filling the dining area.

Dozens of office workers from small and midsize companies were glaring at the owner without bothering to hide their displeasure.

"What's with that ajumma?[520]"

"My appetite's completely gone."

"The food hasn't even come out yet. Should we just leave?"

"Yeah. Let's go."

[520] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman.

"Everyone, let's eat somewhere else. There's a decent set-meal place right up ahead. I may not be an Assistant Manager at a major corporation, but I'm a section manager at a small company, so lunch is on me."

Scrape.

At the middle-aged man's words, five or six of his subordinates stood and followed him.

Similar scenes began unfolding throughout the dining area.

"Customers, that's not what I meant. Customers!"

"What do you mean, it's not? Just watch me never come back here."

"But your orders have already gone in. If you leave like this…"

"Looking at that kitchen, it'll take an hour anyway. Forget it. We're leaving too."

Despite the dining staff's attempts to stop them, the customers streamed out like the receding tide.

Barely a minute later, fewer than ten customers remained in the dining area.

Damn. I can already hear the sound of this place going under.

The owner was trembling with anger and bewilderment.

"You… You people…"

"So which Guild did you say your son was with?"

"Our Minsu is a real hotshot Hunter in Sangdong Guild! Someone like you…"

"What? Which Guild?"

"Sangdong Guild! They even gave him a house and a car."

"Oh, Sangdong Guild. Could you wait just a moment?"

What an incredible coincidence.

Holding back my laughter, I pulled out my smartphone and made a call.

Beep. Beep. Beep. Click.

"Uh, what is it?"

"What do you mean, what is it? Are we only supposed to call each other when we have business?"

"…I sent you the promised four billion won,[521] though."

"Ah, I checked that. It came through fine."

The conversation continued over speakerphone, loud enough for everyone to hear.

Four billion won.[522]

The moment it became clear that what I had said earlier was true, everyone's eyes nearly popped out of their heads. I ignored all the stares and got to the point.

"Do you happen to know a Kim Minsu?"

"Kim Minsu? That's the first I've heard of him."

---

[521] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

[522] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

“You’re a Team Leader in Sangdong Guild, and you don’t even know him? Apparently, he’s a D-rank Hunter in your Guild.”

“D-rank Hunters are a dime a dozen. How am I supposed to know all of them? Is that why you called?”

“Yeah. Bye.”

Getting Im Changsoo’s business card in case he tried to stiff me had been a stroke of genius.

Click.

As soon as I hung up, the owner asked in a faltering voice.

“W-who was that?”

“Didn’t you hear? He’s a Team Leader in Sangdong Guild. Put simply, he’s Mr. Minsu’s boss.”

“…Team Leader? His boss?”

“Oh, and one more thing. He’s also a future employer Mr. Minsu will want to impress. His father is the Guild Master of Sangdong Guild.”

“…”

Her face went white as a sheet.

There was no longer any reason or need to exchange another word with her. I turned toward my mother.

“Let’s go now.”

“Shall we, son?”

My mother, Kim Jeonghee, flashed a broad smile and shoved her work clothes into the sink.

Of course, she didn’t forget to leave the owner with one final remark.

“If you’re a parent, act like one and live right, you ajumma.[523] Where do you get off casually running your mouth about someone else’s precious child?”

The final blow.

The owner lowered her head without answering, and we left the restaurant with light steps.

“Son, have you eaten? There’s cheonggukjang[524] and kimchi pancakes at home.”

“Wow. What a feast.”

The weather was beautiful.

[523] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a married or middle-aged woman.

[524] *Cheonggukjang* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybeans.

Chapter 89

"Son, slow down. You're going to make yourself sick."

"You could quit being a Hunter and become a mukbang[525] streamer."

I finished my meal amid Mom's concern and Hayeon's admiration.

By then, I had polished off five heaping bowls of rice, an entire pot of cheonggukjang,[526] and dozens of kimchi pancakes.

"Whew. I'm finally starting to feel full."

"…You're insane. How much do you normally eat?"

"If it's tasty, it just keeps going in."

I had always eaten a lot, but never this much.

Maybe it was because my metabolism and internal organs had improved beyond comparison. These days, I could put even professional food fighters to shame.

"Maybe I really should become a mukbang[527] streamer."

"No. Those people need to make a living too. Let the humans compete among themselves."

"Are you saying I'm not human?"

"Yeah. To me, you're beyond even a pig."

Hayeon shook her head in disbelief and put down her spoon. I sneaked a look into her rice bowl. Half of it was untouched.

"You'll be punished for wasting rice."

"You sound like an old man."

"Don't you know Koreans run on rice even at death's door? You have to eat if you want to get over your cold faster."

"I don't have an appetite. My head hurts too."

"Did you go to the hospital?"

"Yeah. I took the medicine they prescribed too."

I stared at Hayeon in silence. Her face was flushed, and beads of sweat dotted her forehead. She had left school early, then stubbornly tried to study anyway. It looked like her fever had risen even higher than before.

The medicine doesn't seem to be doing much.

Honestly, there was a much simpler way to cure an illness.

She could be treated by a professional healer or drink one of the potions sold on the market. But most ordinary people avoided both because of the cost.

What a fool.

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[525] *Mukbang* is a broadcast in which the host eats while interacting with viewers.

[526] *Cheonggukjang* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybeans.

[527] *Mukbang* is a broadcast in which the host eats while interacting with viewers.

The reason I had worked nonstop was so my family could live safely, happily, and without getting sick.

Even though I knew why they couldn't spend money so easily, I couldn't help feeling frustrated. How much could one lousy potion cost?

At the very least, circulating qi once would make her feel much better… Huh?

A thought suddenly flashed through my mind, and I stopped.

Wait. Could this actually work?

"Give me your hand for a second."

"Huh?"

"Tsk. I said, give me your hand."

Hayeon looked me up and down as though she had discovered some rare creature.

"What is happening here? Why are you being so gross?"

"You'd rather die than listen to a word I say."

I grabbed her hand.

"We're siblings, okay?"

"Stop talking nonsense."

More carefully than ever, I drew up my internal energy. Slowly—very slowly—I sent a single thread of it through my hand and into Hayeon's body.

"Ah!"

Hayeon cried out. She had clearly noticed the strange sensation caused by my internal energy.

For a moment, I worried it might scatter, but the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique had already reached a realm stage. It obeyed my control without resistance, even inside someone else's body.

This much should be enough.

The trial run was over. Now came the real test.

This time, I guided my internal energy toward Hayeon's dantian.

Normally, that would have been as easy as breathing. Hayeon's body, however, was different. Her acupoints were narrow, and her insides were clogged with waste.

This might be tough.

Even if I separated the modern world and the Murim and considered them independently, I possessed a body far beyond that of an ordinary person.

Hayeon, on the other hand, was an ordinary high school student. It was only natural that nineteen years' worth of waste had accumulated inside her.

Still, I should do as much as I can.

I could attempt this only because I trusted the stability of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique and my own control.

I also remembered to warn Hayeon in case anything went wrong.

"It might hurt a little, so bear with it. Got it?"

"What? What are you doing?"

"Hmm. I suppose you could call it a particularly stable form of traditional Korean medicine."

Mom's eyes widened as she washed the dishes.

"Oh my, traditional medicine? You know how to do that too?"

"I just learned a little."

"That's wonderful. Give it a try."

Hayeon, on the other hand, looked less than enthusiastic.

"Why traditional medicine? I'm not really into that stuff."

"Then trust me and put up with it for a little while."

"Mom, thank you for raising me all these years. Your useless daughter is leaving this world without ever repaying you."

"…"

What the hell, you little shit?

I almost lost control of my internal energy. I could run around for an hour without sweating a drop, but I was starting to feel a little hot now.

"I'm kidding. It's not like you'd do anything bad to your only little sister, right?"

"Then shut up and stay as still as you can, even if it hurts."

"Okay."

I took a deep breath. From this moment on, I was going to clean out Hayeon's acupoints.

The cleaner was me.

The broom was fifteen years of internal energy.

"Ready?"

"Yes, yes, Doctor. But when exactly are we starting?"

"Right now."

The moment I answered, I sent my internal energy flowing.

Whooosh.

A wave of gentle yet powerful internal energy began sweeping through the minor meridians throughout Hayeon's body, washing away the waste that had built up inside her…

"Hoo."

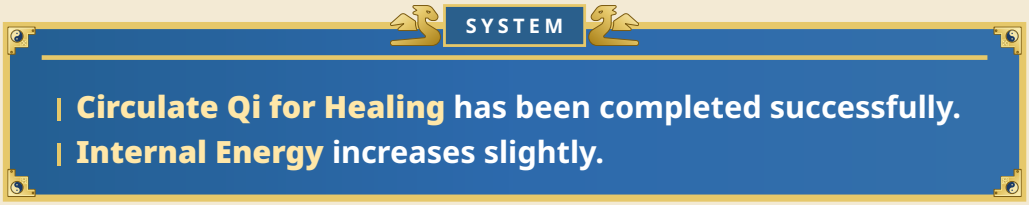
"Phew."

The moment I released her hand, we both exhaled, but for entirely different reasons.

Mine was a sigh of relief.

Hayeon's was one of refreshment.

Ding.



Just as the System said, Circulate Qi for Healing had ended successfully.

The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique accumulated internal energy slowly, but its stability was exceptional. The process had taken a while because so much waste had built up inside Hayeon, but I completed it without any serious trouble.

"Oppa,[528] what was that?"

The fact that she called me Oppa[529] so naturally showed how surprised she was. I wiped away the sweat brought on by the tension and answered.

"I told you. It's a stable traditional medicine treatment."

"That worked just from holding my hand?"

Would it? It only worked because your brother is amazing.

I smoothly changed the subject.

"So? How was it?"

"It hurt at first, but the longer it went on, the better it felt. My body feels lighter, and my headache's gone. How should I put it…"

Hayeon furrowed her brow, then summed it up in a single phrase.

"Like I was reborn? Like all the bad energy inside me got washed away. Ah, damn it. I don't know."

That sounds pretty accurate to me.

In any case, seeing how much better her complexion looked made all the effort worthwhile. I let out a short laugh and said,

"Yeah. Now go wash up."

"Huh?"

"What do you mean, 'huh'? Is your nose stuffed up? You reek, so go take a shower. Now."

"I washed this morning. What smell are you talking abou—Aagh!"

Hayeon realized that a terrible stench was radiating from her own body, grabbed her nose, and began making a huge fuss.

It's only natural.

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[528] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to.

[529] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to.

Where else would the waste inside her body go? It had to come out somehow. Through sweat, for example, or maybe…

Grrrble. Pffft.

Well, it could come out that way too.

"…"

Maybe it was because there had been so much waste, but the stench was unbelievable.

At this point, I had to wonder if she had actually crapped herself.

"Ugh."

As if the sweat soaking her body wasn't enough, her stomach began sending strange signals. Hayeon practically crawled to the bathroom, while Mom stood there with her mouth hanging open.

"My goodness."

"Pretty effective, right?"

"It certainly is. I went to a traditional medicine clinic a few times when I was young, but this is incredible."

"I learned properly. If you ever want to go to a traditional medicine clinic, just come to me. You can do it right now, if you want."

"Should I? Come to think of it, I've been having trouble digesting lately…"

Mom smiled brightly and held out her hand.

That was when—

Bwaaaang. Frrt. Frrt.

"…"

"…"

Mom quietly withdrew her hand.

"…Should we start when Hayeon comes out?"

"…Yes."

Our house had only one bathroom.

Whooosh.

Some time after the sound of the toilet flushing, Mom emerged with the most refreshed expression in the world.

"How do you feel?"

"I feel ten years younger."

That was no exaggeration.

Even nineteen-year-old Hayeon had taken more than an hour to expel all the waste from her body.

Mom was middle-aged, and the amount of waste she had accumulated matched the years she had lived. After more than two hours of Circulate Qi for Healing, her condition must have improved beyond comparison.

"See? Until a little while ago, I had a headache and felt dizzy, but now I'm completely better. I checked my temperature as soon as I came out of the bathroom, and it was normal."

Hayeon stared at me in wonder. As soon as she had emerged from the bathroom, she had polished off two bowls of rice as though she had never complained about having no appetite.

"Where did you learn something like this? Were you a healer, Oppa[530]?"

"A healer? No. I just happened to learn it."

"Which traditional medicine clinic did you learn it at? If it's nearby, I'll go there too."

"…You'd be in big trouble if you went there."

"Why?"

"You don't need to know. Just know that there are lots of scary men there."

"Do they stick the needles in painfully?"

"…They do tend to."

What kind of face would she make if she knew those "needles" were actually knife stabs?

I pushed Hayeon away as she kept peppering me with questions and slipped a hand into my pocket.

Open Inventory.

A translucent inventory window appeared along with the familiar System notification.

If I had been in the Murim, it would have been packed with the spoils I had obtained after defeating Jopil and various weapons.

But this was reality.

It would be nice if the inventories were integrated.

The more I thought about them being separate, the more disappointing it seemed.

Taking just a few high-grade potions to the Murim would be no different from bringing along a few extra lives.

Well, I guess I should be satisfied that leveling up restores me to some extent.

I clicked my tongue inwardly and pulled my hand from my pocket. Two small bottles filled with sloshing red liquid rested in my palm.

[530] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Lesser Potion

- **Type:** Medicine
- **Grade:** Third Rate
- **Description:** A liquid infused with weak healing magic. Readily available on the market.
- **Effect:** Restores the body when consumed. The effect is minimal.

They had been issued as raid supplies yesterday. Since I had no particular use for them, I had put them in my Inventory and left them untouched.

Technically, I'm supposed to return them.

Even lesser potions cost more than 200,000 won[531] apiece. Employers generous enough to hand them out as freely as Team Leader Choi were hard to find.

"Take one each."

"Huh? It's a potion."

"Why go as far as using a potion? I'm perfectly fine now."

"I'm worried there might be side effects. If you don't drink it now, it'll cost you more later."

In truth, I was only offering them as a tonic. Circulate Qi for Healing had no side effects.

"Drink up. You too, Hayeon."

Mom hesitated, then took hers first. Hayeon cautiously took her cue from Mom and followed suit.

Gulp. Gulp.

"How do you feel?"

Hayeon downed hers in one shot and tilted her head.

"Maybe I feel a little stronger. Or maybe not. How should I know? It's not like I've ever had a potion before."

"I guess I don't really know either."

"You'll definitely notice the effect when you're tired or sick. I'll buy a box and keep it here, so drink one whenever that happens."

"A box? How many come in a box?"

"Fifty, if you buy the large one?"

[531] 200,000 won is about $140 or €130; the potion costs more than that.
[532] 200,000 won is about $140 or €130; the potion costs more than that.
[533] Ten million won is about $7,100 or €6,500.

"They're about 200,000 won[532] each, so fifty would be… ten million won[533]? Oppa,[534] are you insane?"

Hayeon smacked my forearm.

"Just because you made some money this time, are you really going to spend it so recklessly? If you keep overspending like that, that 300 million won[535] will disappear in no time."

"It's fine. I've been making good money lately."

"I looked it up online. Once you become a C-rank Hunter, you have to replace your equipment and everything, right? They said you can blow through hundreds of millions[536] like it's nothing."

"I told you, it's fine. I made four billion won[537] yesterday, too."

"If you have four billion won,[538] then spending like this… Wait. How much did you say?"

"Four billion won.[539]"

"…"

Hayeon went completely rigid.

She stared blankly at me, then turned toward Mom.

"Mom, Oppa[540] says he made four billion won.[541]"

Mom gave an awkward smile and nodded.

Only then did Hayeon ask in a trembling voice,

"Is that true?"

"Yeah."

"Four billion won?[542]"

"I told you."

Determination filled Hayeon's eyes.

"Oppa.[543] Can I drop out of school?"

"…"

Didn't you say there was no end to learning?

---

[534] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to.

[535] 300 million won is about $210,000 or €190,000.

[536] Hundreds of millions of won refers to roughly 100–999 million won, or about $71,000–$710,000 and €65,000–€640,000.

[537] Four billion won is about $2.9 million or €2.6 million.

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[543] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man she is close to.

Chapter 90

"A week off?"

"Yes. Exactly as you heard."

Team Leader Choi's call that evening came as a surprise.

A whole week off? Had something happened to the Guild?

That thought reminded me of something troubling.

"Uh, this isn't because of some problem with Sangdong Guild, is it?"

"Sangdong Guild?"

"You know, because of the whole Im Changsoo thing…"

"Ah, you don't need to worry about that. The Guild house remodeling is supposed to be finished in a week."

It was a relief to hear that nothing had happened. But did people really stop raiding because of Guild house remodeling?

Still, a whole week off sounds nice.

For the past seven years, I had lived with my eyes fixed straight ahead, running without rest. Lately, I had been going back and forth between Murim and reality, spending my days without a moment to breathe.

Honestly, I wanted to re—no. Times like this called for working even harder. My voice rang with determination.

"Team Leader. I want to work."

"Ah, but you'll still receive your full salary during your vacation."

"Then I'll see you in a week."

"…"

"I'm hanging up. I need to eat dinner."

"…Yes."

As soon as I ended the call, Hayeon hurried over and bowed politely.

"Oppa.[544] The evening meal has been prepared."

"…Could you stop talking like that? It's giving me goose bumps."

"Switching to casual mode requires a paid purchase."

"You sure found a complicated way to ask for allowance."

I held out two fifty-thousand-won[545] bills, and Hayeon grinned.

"Mom says dinner's ready."

"Oh, what's on the menu?"

"Beef bulgogi.[546] And bean sprout soup that I made."

---

[544] *Oppa* is a form of address a woman uses for an older brother or an older man close to her. Hayeon uses an unusually formal version of it when she bows.

[545] Each 50,000-won bill is about $36 or €32; the two bills total about $71 or €65.

[546] *Bulgogi* is thinly sliced meat marinated and then grilled or pan-cooked.

"Beef bulgogi[547] sounds good."

"Mom says my bean sprout soup is good. She praised me."

"Mom's homemade beef bulgogi[548] never lets you down. It's always fresh, the best, thrilling."

"…"

My thoroughly pissed-off little sister and a table laden with Mom's cooking.

What was so special about vacation? I would eat and sleep to my heart's content at home.

Tap.

Choi Minwoo set down his smartphone after the call ended. Butler Kim, seated across the table from him, asked,

"What did he say?"

"He was already worried about Sangdong Guild."

"The more I see of him, the more interesting that young man becomes. He seems to act without thinking, yet he's quick to grasp the situation."

Choi Minwoo drummed his long fingers on the table.

Even now, some time after Jin Taekyung's sudden appearance, his existence remained a mystery.

When they had first met, Taekyung had seemed like nothing more or less than a diligent F-rank Hunter. Yet yesterday, he had single-handedly swept through a B-rank Gate.

He's getting stronger.

As of yesterday, his suspicions had turned into certainty.

Jin Taekyung was getting stronger. And he was doing so incredibly fast.

"Is there no additional information about Jin Taekyung?"

"No. I've repeatedly reconfirmed everything, but nothing has turned up."

Butler Kim was a man who handled his work thoroughly. But this time was different. Choi Minwoo carefully opened his mouth.

"Butler Kim."

"Yes, Young Master."

"Could you perhaps look for cases of Hunters who awakened a third time?"

"What?"

Butler Kim's eyebrows twitched.

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[547] *Bulgogi* is thinly sliced meat marinated and then grilled or pan-cooked.

[548] *Bulgogi* is thinly sliced meat marinated and then grilled or pan-cooked.

A third awakening? It was a term he had never heard or seen in his entire life. If a Hunter like that had existed, no one would have used the word *reawakening*.

A reawakening was called a reawakening because there was nothing after it.

“Young Master, that…”

Just as Butler Kim was about to express his difficulty, a name flashed through his mind.

Jin Taekyung. If it’s that young man, who knows?

Butler Kim was a living witness who had experienced the Great Cataclysm firsthand. He had accomplished brilliant feats and participated in countless battles.

Yet even to his eyes, Jin Taekyung was special.

Those movements… They were truly remarkable.

Sometimes forceful, sometimes fluid. His transitions between offense and defense were efficient, and he possessed an innate combat sense that told him when to advance and when to retreat.

Watching Jin Taekyung fight, Butler Kim could think of only one word: overwhelming.

A third awakening, huh.

It would take time, but it was worth investigating.

Butler Kim bowed his head.

“I’ll look into it.”

“Thank you. Ah, what are Sangdong Guild’s movements like?”

“They’ve deployed surveillance agents. They’ll probably obtain most of the information within a few days.”

It had not even been half a day since word came that Im Changsoo had been summoned to the Guild Master’s office and beaten like a dog, yet Sangdong Guild’s watchers had already latched on. They were moving faster than expected.

“Their target must be Jin Taekyung.”

“They’ve likely marked him as a key figure, though they’ll begin by thoroughly investigating the entire Guild.”

“What about the other Guild members?”

“I’ve warned them in case someone follows them. But…”

Butler Kim hesitated before adding,

“Shouldn’t we tell Jin Taekyung as well?”

“It’s fine. In fact, I hope Sangdong Guild’s intelligence network is far superior to ours.”

The person who was hardest to understand—and the person about whom the most had already been revealed.

It was like looking into a clear spring and still being unable to see what lay inside.

Even if it meant using Sangdong Guild's power, Choi Minwoo wanted to get closer to Jin Taekyung's true identity.

"More importantly, it seems Sangdong Guild's Master is extremely angry."

"He seems to have grown much more cautious. In the old days, he would have stormed in and caused a scene by now."

"Ah. Could it be?"

Butler Kim smiled at Choi Minwoo's reaction and nodded.

"I'm acquainted with Sangdong Guild's Master."

"An ill-fated relationship?"

"Who knows?"

Butler Kim's smile deepened.

"What can I do for you?"

I answered the real estate agent, a man whose forehead shone brightly.

"I'd like to look at a house."

"Are you looking for a monthly rental? A jeonse lease?[549] Or perhaps…"

"I'm buying."

"Well, well. So you're a young Boss. Sorry, but wait just a moment. Let me take care of this and I'll be right back. It's so urgent I can barely hold it."

I wondered what he needed to take care of, then noticed the toilet paper in his hand.

If that was the issue, he definitely needed to hurry. When I nodded, the real estate agent dashed into the bathroom.

"Have something to eat while you wait on the sofa. There's some mocha bread on the table. Gnnngh…"

Pfft. Pffft.

"…"

I'd never be able to eat mocha bread again.

I lamented inwardly and leaned back against the sofa. On the television, which had already been turned on, a documentary about the Great Cataclysm was playing.

> "Aaaah!"
>
> "Crash! Boom!"

[549] *Jeonse* is a Korean housing lease in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent. The deposit is generally returned at the end of the lease.

> “This is an emergency bulletin. Unidentified phenomena are currently occurring across the country. In response, the government has declared martial law effective immediately…”

People scattered, screaming. Buildings collapsed, flames soared, and news reports announcing the beginning of the Great Cataclysm flashed by one after another. Then the haggard face of the President of the United States filled the screen.

> “We have yet to determine their identity, but one thing is certain: they are our enemies. Not only the enemies of the United States, but of the entire world and all humanity. Even now, countless monsters are passing through Gates and invading Earth.”

Gate.

A Gate meant a door, quite literally. The Demon King Asmodeus had opened that door from beyond another dimension and descended upon Earth with an innumerable army of monsters.

After that, it went exactly as written in the textbooks.

Humanity had been helpless. Downtown areas, rural villages, mountains and seas, jungles… Gates appeared regardless of time or place, and the monsters pouring through them committed murder and destruction.

By the end of the hellish period known as the Bloody Week, which began when the Gates first opened, casualties had reached the tens of millions. The property damage was too vast to calculate accurately.

> The Great Cataclysm: The Most Horrific Ten Years in Human History.

By the time the documentary reached its midpoint alongside the caption, the bathroom door flew open.

“Whew. Now I feel alive.”

The real estate agent plopped down after wiping his sweat-slick forehead.

“Sorry to keep you waiting. You said you were looking to buy, right?”

“Yes.”

“Did you stop by anywhere else before coming here? There must’ve been plenty of real estate offices along the way.”

“No, this is my first stop.”

“Really?”

Judging by the way his eyes rolled around, he seemed to be deciding whether or not to take me for a sucker. I pretended not to notice and held out the note I had prepared.

It had the address written on it.

“I’d prefer to see a property around this address, if possible.”

“This address… That’s in a safe zone.”

“Yes.”

“You really said you wanted to buy, right? Did I hear you wrong because I had to take a dump so badly?”

When I nodded, the man’s eyes traveled subtly up and down.

Jeans and a white T-shirt. Twenty-thousand-won[550] sneakers bought at a market or online. No matter how you looked at me, I wasn’t dressed like a man with money.

“What do you do for a living?”

“I run Gates.”

“Oh, a Hunter? I thought so. You’ve done well for yourself at such a young age.”

A bright smile blossomed across the man’s face. Hunters were one of the most prominent high-income professions. It was hardly unusual for young, successful Hunters to buy expensive houses and cars.

He asked in a much friendlier tone,

“Have you checked the market prices?”

“I searched online on the way here.”

“Then you’re in luck. There actually happen to be a few listings available. Let’s see…”

Perhaps he was excited by the prospect of a sale, because the man began making calls to one person after another.

He spent about five minutes hanging up and dialing again before putting away his smartphone and turning to me.

“I found a listing that’s perfect for you, Boss. If you’re not busy, how about we go see it now?”

“Sure. Why not?”

I was on vacation, so I had no reason to refuse. As I rose, the man beamed.

Vroom.

I sat in the passenger seat of the sedan and watched the scenery pass by. Detached houses stood in rows, shops dotted the streets here and there, and playgrounds and schools appeared along the way.

[550] 20,000 won is about $14 or €13.

"It's changed a lot…"

The agent glanced sideways at me.

"Did you used to live around here?"

"When I was a kid."

I had been in my third year of middle school—sixteen years old—so it had been exactly eleven years since then. I had been born and raised here, so in a way, this was my hometown.

"This area was redeveloped about ten years ago, so it must look pretty different. It used to be an old apartment complex, but when they heard an Association branch was going to be built within thirty minutes of here, they tore the whole thing down."

"I see."

I already knew. Housing prices had skyrocketed as soon as news of the redevelopment broke. The jeonse[551] deposit had risen by hundreds of millions of won,[552] far more than we could afford, so we decided to move.

It wasn't long after Dad died.

On the night before we moved, I saw Mom crying silently.

It was several years later that I learned the place had been my parents' newlywed home.

"We're here."

The agent's voice pulled me from my thoughts. I opened the door and stepped out to find a detached house with a yard.

"This is the address you gave me, Boss. The owner happens to be out, so let's have a quick look and be on our way."

"Ah, just a moment."

Maybe it was nostalgia. The old apartment complex had already been demolished, but the area still felt strangely familiar.

Still… I'm glad it hasn't changed completely.

Some traces of the old scenery remained even after the redevelopment. The real estate agent smacked his lips as he watched me look around, lost in nostalgia.

"You must be happy to be back after all this time. Why don't you take a lap around the neighborhood while you're at it?"

"Is that okay?"

"You're going to sign the contract. Aren't you?"

"No. I mean, yes."

I had to buy this house, no matter what.

---

[551] *Jeonse* is a Korean housing lease in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent. The deposit is generally returned at the end of the lease.

[552] "Hundreds of millions of won" is roughly 200 million to 900 million won: about $140,000–$640,000 or €130,000–€580,000.

The agent chuckled and took out a cigarette.

“Then I should accommodate you. It won’t take long to walk around the neighborhood. I’ll stay here and smoke while I wait, so don’t worry about me.”

After offering him a brief word of thanks, I began walking slowly.

Is this the right way?

I passed through an alley and spotted the supermarket I’d often visited as a child.

“When Oppa[553] was a kid, this place was his hangout. Back when he smoked like crazy in middle school, the old lady here was so old that…”

A gleaming foreign car was parked in front of the supermarket. A man and woman who had been talking together stopped when they saw me.

No—the man was the one who stopped.

He tilted his head, approached me, and asked, “Do you know me?”

[553] *Oppa* is a form of address a woman uses for an older brother or an older man close to her. Hayeon uses an unusually formal version of it when she bows.

Chapter 91

“Do you know me?”

I answered the man striding toward me with a question of my own.

“Who are you?”

Shouldn’t you at least introduce yourself before asking me that?

My bewilderment must have shown on my face, because the man slid his dark sunglasses down, revealing handsome features and a lightly tanned face.

“Park Jihoon.”

Park Jihoon? Well, it wasn’t as if I had only met one or two people over the years.

More importantly, he didn’t look familiar at all.

“I’m sorry, but I think you have me confused with someone else.”

“No, I’m sure it’s you. Didn’t you go to Garam Middle School?”

“Huh?”

That was the school I had attended. I’d moved away before graduating and lost touch with everyone there, but I still remembered it vividly.

“Right? Garam Middle School. And you’re twenty-seven this year.”

“Yes, that’s true, but…”

“I knew it! Jin Taekyung, third year, Class Six!”

He even remembered my year, class, and name when the first two were hazy even to me.

At that point, I couldn’t deny it. I asked the sunglasses-wearing man, who was grinning from ear to ear,

“…You really know me?”

“I’m Jihoon. Park Jihoon! We played soccer together all the time in middle school! We were both terrible students, so our homeroom teacher was always calling us in and smacking us around. You don’t remember?”

Soccer? Getting smacked around by our homeroom teacher?

I opened my mouth, wondering if it could really be him.

“Park Jihwang?”

“That’s right, you punk. I’m Park Jihwang! Oh, right. You wouldn’t know I changed my name.”

“Of course I wouldn’t.”

I didn’t know Park Jihoon, but I knew Park Jihwang.

I never expected to run into an old middle school classmate here. A smile spread across my face.

“Wow, of all places. Some guy I’d never seen before came over acting like he knew me, so I was wondering what was going on.”

“You still should’ve recognized me. It’s not like we knew each other in kindergarten. It was only ten years ago.”

“Even if it had only been five years, I wouldn’t have recognized you. Your face has changed too much.”

“Has it? Ha-ha.”

There was no denying it. The scrawny kid with the dark complexion had turned into someone who could be called handsome wherever he went.

“You didn’t just get better-looking. You filled out, too.”

“Oh, good eye.”

“That’s basic.”

As I recalled, he had been about a head shorter than me. Now our eye levels were roughly the same.

“Damn, you really made it big.”

An unrecognizably changed face, a solid build, a pretty girlfriend, and a foreign car that looked like it would easily cost well over a hundred million won.[554]

Jihwang—or rather, Jihoon—had changed a great deal in the ten years since I’d last seen him, and I knew why.

This guy’s a Hunter, too.

Now that my Qi Sense had reached a higher realm, I could assess people even without using the System.

I guess you could say I can feel his qi.

He was definitely a Hunter. He seemed about as strong as Im Changsoo, perhaps even stronger.

A friend I haven’t seen in ten years turns out to be a Hunter. How strange.

I could even use Qi Sense to read his Level, but I didn’t feel like going that far.

I had met an old friend in a place filled with memories. Right now, I was neither a Hunter nor a martial artist.

I was just an ordinary Jin Taekyung.

“Anyway, it’s really good to see you. You know I was really upset when we lost touch right after you transferred, right?”

“Were you? Things were pretty chaotic back then.”

I had been sixteen, right in the middle of adolescence, and my father had just died. My head had been a mess.

Once I entered high school, I devoted myself to training so I could attend a physical education college. Naturally, I lost touch with all my old friends.

“Ah, right. Things were like that back then. I’m sorry.”

[554] Well over a hundred million won means more than about $71,000 or €65,000; the phrase gives no upper limit.

Maybe he thought he had made a mistake, because Jihwang's—or Jihoon's—smile turned awkward.

"What are you apologizing for? It's my fault for not getting in touch sooner. Do you still live around here?"

"My whole family lives in Seoul now. My girlfriend and I were on our way back from a trip, and I stopped by because this place came to mind."

"Wow. What a triumphant return."

"Don't make it sound so embarrassing. I still have a long way to go before I can call myself successful."

"You've already succeeded plenty. What more could you want?"

We kept talking and laughing. Most of our conversation was about memories from middle school, but that alone made for an enjoyable time.

A considerable amount of time passed before Jihoon's girlfriend subtly hinted that her legs were hurting.

"Oppa,[555] my legs hurt."

"Hm? Then do you want to wait in the car? I'll talk a little longer and be right there."

"…Is that really what you should be saying?"

I had no intention whatsoever of interfering with my friend's love life, so I took the hint and waved him off.

"No, let's talk about the rest next time."

"Next time? Didn't you say something like that ten years ago, too? 'I'll contact you next time.' Then you left and never contacted me once."

Put that way, I had nothing to say. As I smacked my lips, Jihoon held out a business card.

"Forget it. Call this number right now."

> Myeongdong Guild, Team 1
> Hunter Park Jihoon

Myeongdong Guild might not have ranked among Korea's top ten Guilds, but it was easily in the top twenty. It was a major Guild.

And being in Team 1 meant he was recognized as an elite even there. He was good enough to transfer to any decent mid-sized Guild and easily land a Team Leader position.

I figured he was doing well, but this is more than I expected.

Hiding my surprise, I called the number on the card.

Bzzzz.

[555] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses to address an older man, including her boyfriend.

Jihoon checked his smartphone and grinned.

“I’ll call you. We have to grab a drink sometime.”

“We’ll see. If I’m busy, I can’t make it. If I’m free, I’ll come.”

“What kind of answer is that? You came up at the last class reunion. People were asking what you were up to.”

“They talked about me?”

“Why do you sound so surprised? You were popular with the other kids.”

“Was I? I spent all day on the field, so I guess I was friendly with the boys, at least.”

“You were popular with the girls, too. A few of them had crushes on you. You seriously never noticed?”

“…Really?”

“Everyone in the class knew. Why were you the only one who didn’t?”

Damn. They should’ve told me sooner… No, wait.

Not that it mattered now that I had Ms. Songi. I was a one-woman man. Now that I’d met my destined partner, none of that mattered.

“We’re planning to get together soon, so come if I call you. You can see your fan club’s faces, too. Okay?”

“O-Okay.”

Yeah, I’m only going to see their faces. They’re just old classmates.

Jihoon gave me a quiet laugh, then stopped as he was opening the driver’s-side door.

“It was good seeing you.”

“Huh? Oh, yeah.”

“See you again.”

Vroom.

As I watched the car disappear with the roar of its large engine, a thought suddenly occurred to me.

“Were we really that close?”

“You two really looked like childhood best friends.”

“Who? Oh, Taekyung?”

“Who else would I mean?”

“What’s with that tone? You didn’t like him?”

“Yeah. I didn’t want to say it because he’s your friend, Oppa,[556] but honestly, he was kind of off.”

“That’s strange. He was really popular when he was young.”

[556] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses to address an older man, including her boyfriend.

"Why?"

"Plenty of reasons. He was tall, well-built, and great at sports. He was fairly handsome, too. His only problem was that he was completely oblivious when it came to romance."

"Hmm. I didn't care for him. Doesn't he look too much like a complete unemployed bum? What does he do for a living?"

"Hmm. I forgot to ask. He dreamed of becoming a physical education teacher when he was young, so maybe he went into that field."

"He's a twenty-seven-year-old man, so… Is he still in college? Studying for an exam?"

"I don't know either."

"Maybe it's because I'm dating you, but other men just don't measure up. You're handsome, sweet, and incredibly capable."

"Even if it's only lip service, it's nice to hear."

"It isn't. You're a hundred times better than that friend of yours who has nothing going for him but his looks."

"Don't say that. He's a good guy."

"You said you hadn't seen him in ten years. He was even the one who cut off contact. Were you really such close friends that you'd still defend him?"

Park Jihoon smiled gently.

"No. Not at all."

"What do you think?"

The real estate agent's voice was thick with phlegm. He had chain-smoked for an hour while waiting for me, and his complexion looked awful.

"It's nice."

I wasn't just being polite. The two-story detached house with a broad lawn was better than any house I had seen so far.

Four bedrooms, two bathrooms, and a spacious living room.

It looked like something straight out of a fairy tale. I toured the house while half-listening to the real estate agent's detailed explanations, then stepped out through the front gate.

"Listings like this are hard to find. The current owner has several buildings, but he's putting this one up as a quick sale because he's planning to put up another building in Incheon."

"So what's the market price?"

"Exactly what you saw online. 3.38 billion won.[557]"

It was still an amount that made me want to swear, but the house was worth every bit of it.

For my family's safety, and because this place held special meaning for us.

"Please contact me."

"Then…?"

"I'll buy it."

"Oh, you've made an excellent decision, Boss!"

I firmly clasped the hand he offered me.

"Since we're on the subject, would it be all right if I took another look around the neighborhood?"

"…"

"I'm joking."

Look at how hard he was squeezing my hand over one little joke.

"Have a safe trip home."

"Thanks. Take care."

I left the real estate office after putting down a ten-percent deposit. The owner and I had agreed to set a date soon and proceed with the formal purchase. Since he needed cash quickly, everything had been settled without delay.

I'll have to put off moving for a while.

The new house was about an hour from where my family currently lived. Even after buying it, moving in right away would be difficult.

More importantly, Hayeon had her college entrance exam this year.

I would surprise them with the news immediately afterward.

I'll need to remodel the place, too.

I intended to make it as similar as possible to our old home. It had happened a very long time ago, but perhaps because we had lived there for sixteen years, I remembered the layout perfectly.

I'll sign the formal contract and find an interior contractor… What else is there?

I knew how to thrust a spear inside a Gate, but I was a complete novice when it came to any of this. I had no idea where to begin.

I was turning into a dark alley while thinking about this and that when—

Hm?

The back of my neck prickled. My fine hairs stood on end, and the air seemed to shift.

[557] 3.38 billion won is about $2.4 million or €2.2 million.

I sensed someone secretly watching me from behind.

Open Inventory. Summon.

I spun around like lightning, a dagger already in my grip. But…

Meow.

“What? A cat?”

Meow.

A mottled cat jumped down from the wall.

It glanced at me, then slowly wandered away.

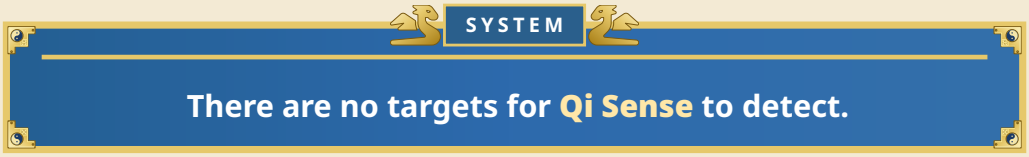
Did I overreact?

My senses had become more acute as they improved. Normally, I would have grown accustomed to them gradually as I developed, but I was progressing too quickly for any adjustment period to matter.

No. Something felt strange this time.

I belatedly raised my Qi Sense, but there was nothing in the deserted alley.

Beep.



If the System said there was nothing, then there was nothing. I must have been especially tired lately.

“Ah, now I suddenly have a craving for samgyetang.[558]”

Since I had thought of it, maybe I should go out to eat with the whole family.

The thought of tender chicken and piping-hot broth put a spring in my step.

In a dark, cramped room, a young man deep in meditation snapped his eyes open.

“Gasp!”

His hair stuck out in every direction, soaked with sweat, and his breathing was ragged. He hurriedly gulped bottled water, then let out a relieved sigh.

“Fuck, that scared me.”

Everything had gone smoothly. In fact, it had been downright boring.

The investigation target happened to be on vacation, and his movements were predictable. Home, convenience store, home. Today, he had traveled as far as an hour away, but tracking him had still been no trouble.

But then…

[558] *Samgyetang* is a Korean chicken soup made with ginseng.

“What the fuck was that? Why did that bastard suddenly turn around and start pulling that shit?”

The moment he saw that sharp gaze, his heart had dropped. If he had not hurriedly severed the Link with the cat, he might really have been discovered.

“He didn’t know, did he?”

The target was only a C-rank Hunter. Compared to the people he had investigated before, the man was far beneath them.

There’s no way. Who do you think I am?

Hong Woojin, a B-rank mage and information broker, shook his head.

He was a master of tracking and surveillance magic. He couldn’t cast flashy offensive spells, but in this particular field, he prided himself on being the best.

“That’s right. There’s no way. It was just a coincidence. A coincidence.”

Hong Woojin muttered the words like a mantra. Anxiety lingered in his voice.

Chapter 92

> **Target Report**
>
> **Name:** Jin Taekyung
>
> **Age:** 27
>
> **Residence:** Address xxx-xxx, Hope Goshiwon[559]. Living separately from his family.
>
> **Family:** Eldest son in a family of one son and one daughter. Father died in an accident eleven years ago. Information on his mother and younger sister attached separately.

Im Chunsoo received the report three days after ordering the investigation. After reading through five densely packed pages, he spoke.

“Hey, Team 1 Leader.”

“Yes, Guild Master.”

The Team 1 Leader sitting across from him answered. Aside from Guild Master Im Chunsoo himself, he was Sangdong Guild’s only A-rank Hunter and Chunsoo’s loyal right-hand man.

“Have you read this report?”

“Not yet.”

“Why not?”

“Because of your instructions, Guild Master. You told me to pass along any new information exactly as it came in, without filtering it first.”

“Then read it now.”

The Team 1 Leader respectfully accepted the report Im Chunsoo held out. His eyes raced across the pages. About ten minutes later, he looked up and muttered,

“This is a little…”

“What do you think of the report?”

“I’ll defer to your judgment, Guild Master.”

“No. Speak frankly.”

After a brief hesitation, the Team 1 Leader answered.

“I think the information is incorrect.”

“Which part, exactly?”

“The subject of the report, Jin Taekyung, was an F-rank Hunter until just two weeks ago. However, he successfully reawakened as a C-rank Hunter. That much is rare, but not impossible.”

---

[559] A goshiwon is a small, inexpensive room-for-rent lodging arrangement, originally associated with students preparing for exams.

“Go on.”

“But according to the testimony of Team Leader Im Changsoo—no, Hunter Im Changsoo—and the others who participated in the raid, Jin Taekyung single-handedly defeated a group of B-rank Minotaurs.”

“At least five. As many as ten, if I remember correctly?”

“Yes. They even said he brought down the boss monster with a single strike.”

“Right. Some measly C-rank Hunter took down a Minotaur Warrior in one blow. Does that make any sense?”

“I don’t think it does.”

“Then what is it?”

He was not asking because he genuinely did not know. He only wanted to confirm once again whether the Team 1 Leader was thinking the same thing he was.

“There are three suspicious possibilities.”

“Let’s hear them.”

“First, the report may be wrong.”

“Who wrote this report? Hong… What was it? Definitely not Hong Gil-dong[560].”

“Hong Woojin. He’s still young and relatively inexperienced, but his skills are well regarded.”

“Right, that Hong Woojin—or Hong Gil-dong[561], or whatever the hell his name is. Check with that bastard again. Put some pressure on him, too. Anyway, what’s the second?”

“Second, Hunter Im Changsoo and the others may have coordinated their stories and lied.”

“Changsoo may be an idiot with his head screwed on wrong, but he’s never lied to me in his life. Continue.”

“The last possibility is that Jin Taekyung is an A-rank Hunter who has not yet been confirmed, or perhaps…”

A troubled look crossed the otherwise composed Team 1 Leader’s face. After a moment, he spoke hesitantly.

“Could he be a third-awakening Hunter?”

“Third awakening?”

“…Yes.”

“Team 1 Leader. It sounds absurd even to you, doesn’t it? A third-awakening Hunter? Does that make any sense?”

The Team 1 Leader lowered his head in lieu of an answer.

Im Chunsoo clicked his tongue at the sight and picked up the report. Extreme cold began to flow from his fingertips.

---

[560] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw and folk hero.

[561] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw and folk hero.

Crackle. Crash!

“Rewrite the report. Finish it by the end of this week and put it on my desk when you come in on Monday. Make it nice and clean.”

“Yes, sir.”

“And what about the others from that Peace Guild—or was it Love Guild?”

“…I was just about to report on that.”

“What? You haven’t found out anything?”

“We’ve finished identifying everyone except for three people.”

Im Chunsoo frowned.

“Three? One must be Jin Taekyung. Who are the other two?”

“The Guild Master and Team Leader of Peace Guild.”

He had heard about them from his son. The young Team Leader was an insolent brat, while the middle-aged Guild Master was a clueless man who had done nothing but chuckle throughout the entire raid.

“Why those two?”

“There was a Lock on them.”

“What?”

“Exactly as I said. Not only their personal information, but even their account details are all under security restrictions. The Audit Team is at a loss as well.”

“Did you skimp on the money?”

Running a Guild required help from government agencies. The corrupt officials who worked for them had no qualms about accepting bribes in exchange for information.

“I already gave them plenty…”

“And yet?”

“They seem very reluctant on their end as well. They said an upper agency had placed the security lock, making it difficult for them to touch.”

Im Chunsoo was dumbfounded.

The Guild had existed for less than a month. Its entire membership was too small to fill a single raid team. At that size, it would hardly be strange to call it a social club instead of a Guild.

And yet, who the hell were those bastards to have a Lock placed on them?

“Huh. Look at these bastards.”

“What should we do?”

“Don’t dig any deeper into that for now. Leave it alone. And make damn sure the people we paid this time keep their mouths shut.”

During the Great Cataclysm, Im Chunsoo had been famous for his fiery temper. But running a Guild had taught him one important lesson.

To achieve a goal—and to gain results beyond that goal—one had to remain calm and cautious.

"So aside from those three, you've identified everyone?"

"Yes. Completely."

The Team 1 Leader's meticulous nature had earned Im Chunsoo's trust. Chunsoo nodded.

"Deal with those two locked targets as I said. For now, focus only on Jin Taekyung. Mobilize a few people from the Guild Audit Team and increase the surveillance separately."

"Separately…?"

"Yeah. This report is no good. And when you think about it, our Guild Audit Team is no slouch either, is it?"

"That's true, but…"

The Team 1 Leader faltered. He remembered what Hong Woojin had repeatedly stressed when he commissioned the investigation.

> "The moment I accept this assignment, it becomes my job. Got it? Within a week, I'll find out what color underwear the bastard wore that day, so leave it to me. If you start something on your end and the surveillance target catches on, you'll ruin my job."

Hong Woojin had little experience, but word had spread that he was good at his job. His arrogant tone aside, his professionalism had inspired confidence, and the Team 1 Leader had personally given him his word.

I should probably tell him.

But the objection he was about to raise slipped straight back down his throat at Im Chunsoo's next words.

"Why? Something else you want to say?"

"Oh, no, sir. I'll relay it exactly as you said."

"Good. You can go."

Im Chunsoo had been in a bad mood lately. It was the Team 1 Leader's job to keep him appeased as much as possible and guide him in a favorable direction.

It'll be fine, right? It'll be fine.

Even after leaving the Guild Master's office, the Team 1 Leader could not shake his unease.

Home. Vacation.

Just thinking about those two words made me happy. The reality was every bit as wonderful.

Except…

Bzzzz. Bzzzzzz.

“Ah, this is driving me crazy.”

I swatted a fly with lightning speed. Not with an ordinary palm, either, but one charged with internal energy. I tossed the fly, dead in one strike, into the trash and returned to the sofa.

“Why the hell are there so many fucking flies?”

Hayeon, who had briefly come out into the living room to get a drink of water, let out a deep sigh.

“It’s summer, you idiot, Oppa[562].”

“I’m telling you, this is more than that.”

“How many could there possibly be? There was only one just now.”

“That’s the problem. They keep coming in one at a time. Every time I kill one, another shows up from somewhere.”

“How many have you killed?”

“I swear to heaven, I’ve killed at least a hundred since this morning.”

“Look at you exaggerating. This is why men are…”

“I’m serious!”

“Okay, okay.”

Wow. This was driving me insane. I tore at my hair and swatted another fly. A hundred? That was no exaggeration. What the hell was wrong with this neighborhood that one house could be overrun with so many flies?

Did someone smear honey on the windows?

At first, they had merely been annoying. Like Hayeon said, I assumed they were only around because it was summer.

But the more time passed, the more I realized that something was strange.

It was after I’d killed about thirty of them.

These damn things kept coming in without a break! I would kill one, then another would come in. I would kill that one, and a different fly would take its place.

Even after I closed every window and searched the whole house with Qi Sense, the nightmare of the fly army continued.

Bzzzzzz.

“See? Another one came in before we could even turn around. Where the hell are these things coming from?”

[562] *Oppa* is how a younger sister addresses an older brother in Korean.

I carefully searched for some tiny gap I had failed to notice, but I could not figure it out. They seemed to be coming through spaces barely large enough for a single ant to pass through.

“Stop swatting them and leave them alone. Then they’ll quiet down.”

“What kind of creative bullshit is that? You think they’ll sit still just because you leave them alone? We obviously won’t be able to sleep with them buzzing all night.”

“The flies in my room stay still.”

“What?”

“There are about three in my room, too. They bothered me at first, so I thought about killing them, but when I left them alone, they stopped flying around and just sat on my desk.”

“That’s only temporary. They probably fly around like crazy when you’re not looking.”

“I think they’re just lazy flies. They haven’t moved even once.”

“Say something that makes sense.”

“I’m serious. Want to bet a hundred thousand won[563]?”

“You even have a hundred thousand won[564]? You’re supposed to be studying for exams.”

“Of course I do. It’s the money you gave me last time.”

“You’re going to bet against me with the allowance I gave you?”

“If you’re scared, you can just die.”

“…Deal.”

Shit. So this was how money went around in circles.

We went straight to Hayeon’s room. She pointed at a fly sitting quietly on her desk and grinned triumphantly.

“See? I was right, wasn’t I? Hurry up and hand over the hundred thousand won[565].”

“Hand over what? We need to run an experiment first.”

I brought my palm down over the fly. I struck at an ordinary person’s speed, slow enough for the fly to dodge easily. But then…

Flinch. Scramble.

The fly jumped in alarm and scurried away as fast as its legs could carry it.

I was dumbfounded. Hayeon looked just as baffled.

“Sis.”

“Y-Yeah?”

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[563] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.
[564] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.
[565] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

"Are all flies these days like that?"

"M-Maybe they do? Anyway, give me the hundred thousand won[566]."

"I'll give it to you. I will. But isn't that fly strange?"

"A fly is a fly. That one's just a little strange."

"What kind of fly acts like that? I've seen goblins and Minotaurs in my life, but I've never seen a fly that flies around so little."

The instant I finished speaking—

Bzzzzzz—

"…"

"…"

Suspicious. Way too suspicious.

The timing was questionable enough, but the way its wings moved—as if it were trying hard to look ordinary—was even stranger. Even its flight was awkward and unsteady.

Never mind that. It gives me the creeps. This feeling is weirdly familiar.

Where had I felt something like this before?

Oh, right. That alley I had walked through two days ago, on my way home from viewing the house.

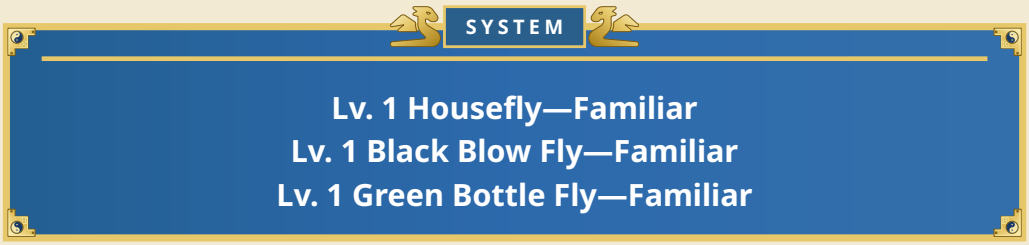
That strange sense of déjà vu, as though someone were watching me.

Am I really just being oversensitive?

I glared at the fly and raised my Qi Sense. Its activation range now extended to a radius of seventy meters[567], spreading into every corner of the house.

And then something no one could have expected happened.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



"…?"

What the hell is this?

[566]100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

[567]Seventy meters is about 230 ft.

Chapter 93

What a bunch of amateurs.

Hong Woojin was furious enough to burst. If he had entered the cat's body like last time, he would have puffed up its fur and hissed.

But right now, he was a rice weevil smaller than a fingernail. The most he could do to express his anger was hide in the gap beneath the refrigerator and wriggle.

Bzzzzzz.

That bastard's coming in again.

The target of his anger was the flies that kept entering the house.

Woojin did not know who was behind them, but whoever it was seemed to think they were being careful by sneaking the flies in one at a time. Instead, they were only putting Jin Taekyung further on guard.

"Ugh, these damn flies."

Whoosh. Smack!

A predictable end. Hong Woojin grew anxious, worried that Jin Taekyung might notice him.

Bastards like that have no professional courtesy, and they're stupid on top of it.

Most Hunters would never have noticed, but he recognized it immediately.

That fly was a Familiar being controlled by a mage. The proof was the incredibly faint mana that only another mage could sense.

Who hired the bastard? Was it Sangdong Guild after all?

If that was the case, he would have to quit this assignment right away. He was a professional with immense pride in his abilities.

He could not tolerate an intruder interfering with his sacred workspace.

I warned them over and over…

No matter how well you handled a job, there were times when a single loach released by an impatient client muddied the water. Just like now.

"Are all flies like that these days?"

"Th-They could be, couldn't they? Anyway, give me the hundred thousand won[568]."

"I will. I'll give it to you, but… don't you think that fly's a little strange?"

Damn it. He knew this would happen.

Swallowing his curses, Hong Woojin wriggled with all his might. He was crawling deeper into a place no human eyes could reach when—

A jolt.

…Huh?

[568] 100,000 won is about $71 or €65.

A strange sensation seized him, as though his body had suddenly floated into the air. It had never happened once since he began using Familiar magic.

Is it because this Familiar is too small?

The sensation lasted only an instant, but Hong Woojin could not shake off his unease. For a moment, he wondered whether it had been some kind of detection spell, but he soon shook his head.

It definitely wasn't magic.

That was not merely because Jin Taekyung was a non-mage Hunter. After all, this was a world where anyone could obtain magical equipment if they had enough money.

But mages recognized their own kind. As a B-rank mage, there was no way he could fail to distinguish a detection spell.

The connection must have weakened for a moment. Yes. That has to be it.

What finally convinced him that he had imagined it was Jin Taekyung's reaction.

"Maybe its wing's injured. This fly's looking pretty weak."

Smack!

With a crisp sound, Jin Taekyung returned to the living room and sprawled out on the sofa. He chuckled at a variety show for a while, but soon the house was filled with loud snoring instead of laughter.

Hrrrnk. Hrrrnk.

Only then did Hong Woojin relax.

Of course. What could a C-rank Hunter who was an F-rank until recently possibly know? What happened two days ago must have been a complete coincidence, too.

The incident from two days ago still lingered in the back of his mind. He had been watching Jin Taekyung through a cat Familiar and had been startled by what happened. For some reason, it had continued to bother him ever since. Now, at last, he felt he could breathe a little easier.

If he can't even recognize a shoddy Familiar like that, then that says it all.

There was only one problem: the lazy bastard had no intention of moving at all…

I'll have to monitor him a little more boldly from now on.

Hong Woojin had chosen a rice weevil from among all the living creatures in the world because he still harbored a sliver of caution toward Jin Taekyung.

But now, it seemed safe to leave the body of this tiny, painfully slow insect.

Let's meet in a different form tomorrow, Jin Taekyung.

Pop.

Hong Woojin severed the Link. The creature hiding beneath the refrigerator was no longer a Familiar. It was nothing more than a small, fragile rice weevil.

And then—

Hrrrnk…

Jin Taekyung's snoring gradually faded before stopping altogether.

A faint presence disappeared. I could sense the change only because I was focusing every one of my senses.

Did he leave?

I opened my eyes while pretending to stretch. The first place I looked was the gap beneath the refrigerator.

Only ten minutes ago, its Level window had carried the tag "Familiar." Not anymore, now that the Link had been severed.

"Yaaawn. Is there anything to eat…?"

I got up from the sofa and casually wandered around the house. Only then could I be certain.

There aren't any Familiars left.

The only things caught by my Qi Sense were a few ordinary flying insects. There was not a Familiar among them.

The incessant buzzing of wings had stopped, too.

They had probably gotten spooked by what just happened, so at least they would not show their faces for the rest of the day.

Damn it. A Familiar?

Familiar magic.

It was a kind of mental magic used by mages. The caster formed a mental connection with the creature chosen as a Familiar and, depending on the caster's skill, could even control it at will.

That was my first time experiencing it firsthand.

A melee Hunter was not automatically a master of every weapon, and mages were the same. Mental magic, in particular, was said to be among the more difficult branches.

Why would people like that come after me?

The reason I thought of them as "people" rather than "someone" was that there had been two Familiars. The two could have been working together, or they might not have been.

Still, I had a rough idea of who had sent them.

Who else could it be but Sangdong Guild?

The only place I had formed some kind of grudge against in the real world was Sangdong Guild. More precisely, Im Changsoo.

When you mess with someone's child, the father comes running.

Im Chunsoo, the A-rank Hunter known for being cold-blooded and foul-tempered.

If what happened today was his order, this would not end easily.

But…

I can't just sit back and take it.

I could let the fact that they had followed me two days ago go. I could tolerate that.

But I could not tolerate what happened today. This was my home, the place where my beloved family lived. They had crossed my one inviolable boundary.

How should I screw these bastards over…?

I was thinking about it when Hayeon's bedroom door flew open.

Her face was stiff. Had they used a Familiar to pull something behind my back? My thoughts grew frantic.

"Oppa[569]."

"What is it? What happened? Is there something strange in your room?"

"No, it's not that."

"Then what is it?"

"Why haven't you given me the hundred thousand won[570]?"

"…"

Right. I had been underestimating you far too much.

The next morning, I left the house as soon as dawn broke.

My eyes felt gritty from staying alert with Qi Sense all night in case another Familiar intruded, but I shook off the fatigue by circulating my qi.

"Where should I take you?"

"Ilsan Lafesta, please."

The taxi sped along the wide-open roads without a hitch, reaching the destination much faster than I had expected.

Is this my first time coming to the Store since I visited once a few years ago?

The Store, located in the center of Ilsan, stood out clearly even from a distance. For one thing, it was overwhelmingly larger and more splendid than the shops around it.

There was another thing that set it apart from ordinary stores. At the entrance, guards in suits were screening the customers.

---

[569] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses to address an older brother or an older man close to her.

[570] 100,000 won is about $71 or €65.

“Sir, we’re adults, I’m telling you!”

“No.”

“We’re adults, so why aren’t we allowed inside?”

“Because the fingerprint scanner says you’re not adults.”

“Isn’t it broken?”

“No.”

“Ah, shit, just let us in!”

“‘Shit’?”

Five or six teenagers who looked obviously young flinched and took a step back.

“…What?”

“Is that any way to treat customers?”

“Customers? Ha. You little shits, seriously.”

The guard rubbed the corners of his eyes with a weary expression. He was not an ordinary adult man but a hired guard Hunter. Even if a whole crowd of professional fighters came instead of five or six minors, they would not be able to force their way in.

“My customers are Hunters or civilian adults who’ve been issued membership cards. Not high school punks like you.”

“…”

“Are you leaving while I’m asking nicely, or should I call the police?”

People like that existed everywhere. Especially in a Store filled with all kinds of goods ordinary people could never access.

“…Hey, hey. Let’s go.”

Only after the kids loitering out front had left did the guard notice me. He addressed me politely.

“What brings you here?”

“I’d like to purchase something.”

“Please present your membership card or Hunter certification.”

“Here.”

“I’ll need to complete the verification process.”

Only after my certification had been checked and my fingerprints scanned was I given an admission pass.

“As a C-rank Hunter, you may access up to the third floor.”

The Store stocked different items on each floor. I had visited once when I was an F-rank Hunter, but the second floor had been the highest I could access at the time. I had never even gotten to look around above it.

“Have a pleasant time.”

“Thanks. Take care.”

Once I passed through the doors, I saw endless rows of glass display cases.

The space was incomparably larger than an ordinary shop, yet there were only a handful of customers in sight.

Well, it would be strange if this place were crowded.

Only a tiny minority could shop here: Hunters, who made up just 0.1 percent of Korea's population, and civilians with enough social influence to be issued membership cards.

They were the Store's main customers.

"This item was manufactured by domestic S Company and has a built-in alarm spell, making it useful for security…"

"This brooch was made by overseas M Company. With its beautiful, tasteful design and built-in shield spell, it's perfect for your wife's personal protection…"

The employees were busy explaining their products to customers.

That was right. The Store was a kind of luxury department store where people could buy expensive magical goods that were difficult to obtain through ordinary channels.

"Then I'll take that one and this one. Bring me that, too."

"Don't you have anything with better performance? Don't worry about the price. Bring me some options."

There might not have been many customers, but their purchasing power was unmatched.

I was staring blankly at people buying goods that cost at least several million won[571] when a pretty female employee approached and bowed.

"Hello. I'm Assistant Manager Kim Seonhee from the Ilsan Store. I'll be assisting you today."

"Ah, yes."

They had treated me politely the last time I visited, too, but not to this extent.

Now that I was a C-rank Hunter, the customer service was considerably more attentive.

"Is there a particular product you're looking for?"

"I'd like to buy some raid equipment."

The employee's expression brightened. The Store carried countless magical goods, but Hunter equipment was among the most expensive of them all.

And I was a C-rank Hunter. Even a mid-level Hunter could spend hundreds of millions of won[572] on a single piece of equipment.

---

[571] Several million won is roughly 2–9 million won, or about $1,400–$6,400 or €1,300–€5,800.

[572] Hundreds of millions of won is roughly 100–900 million won, or about $71,000–$640,000 or €65,000–€580,000.

Naturally, a sales employee would be delighted at the thought of adding that kind of sale to her record.

"I'll show you to the third floor."

As she turned toward the escalators, I spoke.

"No, please take me to the second floor."

"Pardon? But to purchase C-rank Hunter equipment, you'll need to go to the third floor…"

"It's fine. I'm looking for weapons for low-rank Hunters."

I pretended not to notice her expression darkening and stepped onto the escalator first.

I wonder if they have anything useful for killing rats.

The time had come to fill my Inventory.

"It's fine. I'm looking for weapons for low-rank Hunters."

Assistant Manager Kim Seonhee secretly sighed at the customer's words. As someone unusually concerned about her sales numbers, this was far from welcome news.

I need a good sales record this month if I want to get promoted.

The colleague who had joined the company at the same time as her and worked at the Seoul branch was already a Team Leader. Whether it was luck or business savvy, every customer she encountered was apparently a big spender.

Compared to her…

"This one looks good."

"Ah, yes. This product was manufactured using an F-rank Magic Gem…"

Kim Seonhee quickly pulled herself together and began her explanation. The customer had picked up a dagger with a black-painted blade.

Compared to the other weapons, it was nothing special. It did not even have magic embedded in it. It was just an ordinary consumable.

"How much is it?"

"It's currently on sale as part of our summer promotion, so we're offering it at the low price of 520,000 won[573]."

"Hmm. That's expensive."

"…"

[573] 520,000 won is about $370 or €340.

[574] Several hundred million won is roughly 200–900 million won, or about $140,000–$640,000 or €130,000–€580,000.

How much did a C-rank Hunter make a year again? Didn't their basic allowances alone amount to several hundred million won[574]? Kim Seonhee found it ridiculous, but silently waited for the customer to make his choice.

"Ah, well, I guess it can't be helped. I'll buy it. Give me one."

"…Yes."

The look on his face, as if parting with the money were killing him, was utterly obnoxious. Kim Seonhee swallowed a curse as she picked up the dagger when—

"No. Not that one."

"Excuse me?"

"The one next to it."

Her gaze shifted to the side. One hundred daggers were neatly arranged inside a storage box.

"They're the same product, sir."

"I know. Give me one of those."

"…Are you referring to that storage box?"

"Yes. Give me one box of those. And one box of that, too. And that one…"

That was the moment Assistant Manager Kim Seonhee's worries about her sales numbers disappeared.

Chapter 94

"Three hundred fifty million won[575]."

The employee's voice trembled as she processed the payment, and my hand shook as I passed her the card.

Good lord. Three hundred fifty million won[576]? In barely an hour, I had blown through three years' worth of salary from back when I worked like a dog.

No. Let's look on the bright side.

This was money spent to protect my family from the people watching us.

I could keep earning money anyway, and the things I bought today would last me a long time.

Beep.

- Approval complete.

"Your payment has gone through."

Thanks to me, this young lady was the only one who had hit the jackpot. I took my card back from Assistant Manager Kim Seonhee, whose smile stretched from ear to ear.

"So that's everything, right?"

"Ah, if you give us your address, we can have everything delivered."

"That's all right. I have somewhere to go right now."

Delivery, my ass. The moment I got out of everyone's sight, I could just store everything in my Inventory.

The System sure is convenient at times like this.

With that thought, I accepted enough shopping bags to fill both hands. Of course, they weren't ordinary paper bags. They were tough, sturdy leather shopping bags supposedly made from ogre hide. They had been free gifts, but instead of making me happy, they just made my stomach hurt.

"Take care."

"Please be sure to visit us again!"

"…Ah, yes."

She bowed at a perfect right angle as she held out her business card, and I accepted it.

One obsessed with sales figures. Their name: salesperson.

[575] About $250,000 or €230,000 at the project conversion rates.
[576] About $250,000 or €230,000 at the project conversion rates.

I stopped by a nearby restroom and stored the things I had bought at the Store in my Inventory before hailing a taxi. These days, I regretted never getting my driver's license.

"Apartment A in Ilsan, please."

The moment I sat down in the passenger seat, I pulled out my smartphone and searched for information.

The search term was…

Familiar.

The instant I tapped the search button, related results flooded the screen.

A considerable amount of it was restricted information that ordinary people couldn't access without Hunter certification. One title in particular caught my eye.

No Joke: Don't Use Familiar Magic. It Made My Hair Fall Out.

It was a title that resonated with the soul. How could I not click it?

Ah, so this is where it was posted.

The post was on a famous Korean Hunter forum.

It had made the monthly best list and racked up over a hundred thousand views and more than two thousand comments.

Let's see what it says.

Click!

No Joke: Don't Use Familiar Magic. It Made My Hair Fall Out.

I'm an active B-rank mage.

I've been around for a while and make pretty good money as a freelance Hunter. Please understand that I can't reveal my exact stats.

Anyway, I'm writing this for exactly the reason in the title.

Familiar magic hit me with the hair-loss beam…

I'm still in my twenties, but the top of my head is classmates with a two-thousand-year-old mummy. Fuck me.

Before any assholes start arguing, let me make one thing clear: My family has always had thick hair. I've even seen a picture of my great-grandfather from the Japanese occupation[577], and the man looked like the Rapunzel of Joseon[578].

Anyway, Familiar magic. This shit is a real double-edged sword.

Any of you guys who are mages will know this, but mental magic isn't exactly common. Even civilians can make a living if they learn a single skill, right?

For a mage, mental magic is exactly like that. If you have this one thing, you can live well no matter what.

But fuck, your hair falls out. And it keeps falling out.

Anyone here ever washed their hair with a Superior Potion? I have.

---

[577] Japan ruled Korea from 1910 to 1945.

[578] Joseon was a Korean dynasty that lasted from 1392 to 1897.

You crazy bastards, I spent tens of millions of won[579] washing my hair just once. I tried every kind of crazy shit imaginable, but even that only worked for a little while.

When nothing worked, I finally went to a regular doctor. The bastard let out a long sigh and asked me:

“You’re a mental-magic mage, aren’t you?”

That’s exactly what he said, word for word. I nearly jumped out of my skin and asked how he knew. Then he told me something truly horrifying.

More than ninety percent of mental-magic mages suffer from hair loss. Among the ones who use the more difficult Familiar magic, it’s one hundred percent.

Apparently, we work our brains so hard that sooner or later, even people with thick hair end up bald.

At first, I thought he was talking out of his ass, but I looked into it and found out it was true.

I hurriedly joined a mental-magic mage café[580] and searched for people like me, only to find that ninety-eight of its one hundred members suffered from hair loss.

When they heard about my situation, they said it was already too late. Potions only restore cells temporarily, so using them too often ends up killing the hair-follicle cells instead.

The café[581] offered to upgrade my membership if I posted a review of my medical consultation. I ignored them, quit the café[582], and am now searching for my own cure…

Three-line summary:

1. Mental-magic mages are great. But you lose your hair instead.
2. Potions are useless. Use hair-loss-prevention shampoo and go to a regular hospital instead. Hair must be treated with heart and desperation, not magic.
3. I will not give up.

That’s all.

“…”

By the time I finished reading, my vision had blurred. So even the mages I had always envied—the people who seemed to have everything—had hardships of their own.

“Are you all right, sir?”

---

[579] “Tens of millions of won” is roughly 20–90 million won, or about $14,000–$64,000 and €13,000–€58,000.

[580] A Korean online café is a membership-based internet community, often organized around a shared interest.

[581] A Korean online café is a membership-based internet community, often organized around a shared interest.

[582] A Korean online café is a membership-based internet community, often organized around a shared interest.

“I’m fine… Hngh.”

“What’s wrong?”

“Ah, it’s nothing. I’m fine.”

Of all things, the taxi driver happened to be bald, too. Feeling like a sinner, I lowered my head toward my smartphone.

Below the post, I found more than two thousand comments.

> ㄴ Anonymous#232: Give us the one-line summary.
>
> ㄴ Author: [Comment hidden due to severe profanity.]
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#112: Is the first commenter even human? I cried. I’m rooting for you. Stay strong.
>
> ㄴ Author: Thanks…
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#1512: I don’t know about the rest, but the second commenter seems to be suffering from hair loss, too. But after reading the whole thing, it sounds like you make a lot of money. Can’t you live without some hair? Just wear a good wig.
>
> ㄴ Author: [Comment hidden due to severe profanity.]
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#4885: Wow, I’m seeing a Familiar mage here. You guys don’t realize it, but the author is a real aristocrat. Even among B-ranks, the income doesn’t compare. Neither does the treatment.
>
> ㄴ Author: What good is money when you don’t have hair?
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#4885: Now that I think about it, you’re right.
>
> ㄴ Author: If you’re going to comfort me, see it through, you son of a bitch.
>
> .
>
> .
>
> .
>
> ㄴ Moderator: Congratulations! Your post has been selected as a popular post!
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#5252: □□□□□□□□□□
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#8984: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□
>
> ㄴ Author: Am I supposed to laugh at this or not?
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#2652: How can you laugh when you don’t have any hair?
>
> ㄴ Author: [Comment hidden due to severe profanity.]
>
> ㄴ Author: Thanks for the overwhelming support. Looks like I’m about to make the monthly best list and enter the Hall of Fame. If you have any questions, leave them below. I’m working right now, but I’ll drop in and answer them whenever I get a chance.

> ㄴ Anonymous#9665: You said you're a freelancer. What kind of work do you mainly do?
>
> ㄴ Author: Freelancer is a nice way of putting it. What I do is similar to running a private detective agency. I've tracked high-level criminals—Hunters, of course—and I've also taken on an affair case at a nouveau riche family's house.
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#915: Oh… You must make a lot. How much?
>
> ㄴ Author: Depends on the job, obviously. Still, after working for a few years, I put up a building in Seoul. The house I live in is in my name too.
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#5252: Show us proof of your house.
>
> ㄴ Author: I'm outside working right now. I'll post proper proof later, so wait until then.
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#9882: What does being at work have to do with it? Familiars are remote-controlled anyway, aren't they?
>
> ㄴ Author: Remote control still has a range limit, dumbass. Do you use your home Wi-Fi while you're traveling in the US?
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#9882: Sry.
>
> ㄴ Author: Five hundred meters[583] is the maximum range for a Familiar connection. I've been increasing it little by little, but it's hard. If the Link gets forcibly severed, my stomach churns and I feel like I'm going to puke. There's also a risk of mana backflow.
>
> ㄴ Anonymous#9882: So you have to stay within five hundred meters[584] no matter what.
>
> ㄴ Author: Yeah. To work safely, maybe three hundred meters[585]? You have to prepare for anything that might happen. Most people probably do the same.

I was scrolling through the comments when I suddenly stopped.

Had I just stumbled across something important?

The connection to a Familiar breaks beyond five hundred meters[586]?

The maximum distance was that much, and the safe working distance was three hundred meters[587].

In other words, if the author's comments were true, then the people who had controlled the Familiars yesterday had been somewhere not far from my house.

And they'd be going bald, too. Maybe completely bald.

[583] Five hundred meters is about 1,640 ft, or 0.31 mi.
[584] Five hundred meters is about 1,640 ft, or 0.31 mi.
[585] Three hundred meters is about 980 ft, or 0.19 mi.
[586] Five hundred meters is about 1,640 ft, or 0.31 mi.
[587] Three hundred meters is about 980 ft, or 0.19 mi.

There was a strong possibility they were wearing wigs, but knowing that couldn't hurt.

I kept searching for information about Familiar magic and managed to put together a few facts.

For a B-rank mage, the maximum Familiar connection distance is five hundred meters[588]. The safe distance is three hundred meters[589]. If a Familiar dies, the Link is forcibly severed, and the caster also takes a slight hit.

And I realized one more thing: why they had gone out of their way to use an expensive Familiar mage to watch me.

What the hell? Tiny Familiars can slip past most detection magic?

It was like this: detection magic was a net, while tiny Familiars like flies and rice weevils were too small to get caught in it.

Of course, there were products with built-in top-of-the-line detection magic capable of catching even those. But when I looked them up, they cost five hundred fifty million won[590]—and that was the summer special price.

"…"

What part of that was supposed to be a summer special? I already had plenty of expenses coming my way. Five hundred million won[591], my ass.

One more reason to catch them myself.

My thoughts suddenly turned to the other Guild members, too. Had Familiars been attached only to my family?

I still didn't know the exact identity of the person who had commissioned this. Sangdong Guild was only the prime suspect.

"That'll be 8,400 won[592]."

"Ah, yes. Here you go."

I paid the taxi fare and got out. The entrance to the apartment complex, which had always looked exactly the same, seemed a little unfamiliar today.

The watcher's presence bothered me like a thorn caught in my throat.

Should I contact Team Leader Choi?

I was looking at his number saved on my smartphone when—

"Oppa[593]!"

A familiar swan[594] in a green tracksuit and round glasses waved at me, her greasy hair tied tightly back.

"Oh, y-yeah."

---

[588] Five hundred meters is about 1,640 ft, or 0.31 mi.
[589] Three hundred meters is about 980 ft, or 0.19 mi.
[590] About $390,000 or €350,000 at the project conversion rates.
[591] About $360,000 or €320,000 at the project conversion rates.
[592] About $6 or €5.40 at the project conversion rates.
[593] *Oppa* is a term a girl or woman uses to address an older brother or an older man she is close to.
[594] In Korean slang, a "swan" is an unemployed woman.

"What's with that reaction?"

"I guess I'd rather not acknowledge knowing you in public. You could say I'm embarrassed…"

"You're embarrassed by your one and only little sister? Huh?"

"Go buy some clothes. What are you doing wearing a tracksuit again when you left the clothes you bought at the department store last time at home?"

"You should worry about yourself. You're one to talk, when you go around wearing the same kinds of clothes every day."

Hayeon's pointed remark left me speechless for a moment. I had paid three hundred million won[595] only an hour or two ago, but I was still wearing nothing but jeans and a T-shirt. Apparently, the old grime of being an ordinary little citizen, caked on over twenty-seven years, had not yet completely washed off.

"A-Anyway. Where are you going?"

"Where am I going? The convenience store!"

Hayeon, who had been sulking until just now, began grinning foolishly.

What's gotten into her?

I asked in a bemused voice.

"Why are you so excited? Is your heart already pounding at the thought of raiding the convenience store?"

"Raiding, my ass. I'm going to buy canned tuna."

"Canned tuna? Are we having tuna kimchi stew for lunch today?"

"No! We're not!"

"…What's with you today, seriously? Have you been drinking?"

"You'll be like this, too, when you see this little one."

Despite my reaction, Hayeon only continued to grin strangely, unlike her usual self. Then she lowered the zipper of her tracksuit and pulled something out from inside her clothes.

A tiny ball of white-and-yellow fur wriggled in her palm.

Meeoow.

"…A kitten?"

"Cute, right? I went out to sort the recycling earlier, and someone had abandoned it in a box. It had been left there for anyone who wanted to raise it."

"…"

"I don't know what kind of bastard abandoned it, but it's pitiful, isn't it? What did it ever do wrong? Right, Oppa[596]?"

"…Yeah. It's not the animal's fault."

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[595] About $210,000 or €190,000 at the project conversion rates.

[596] *Oppa* is a term a girl or woman uses to address an older brother or an older man she is close to.

“I got Mom’s permission to foster it, even if it’s only for a little while. You’re okay with it, too, right?”

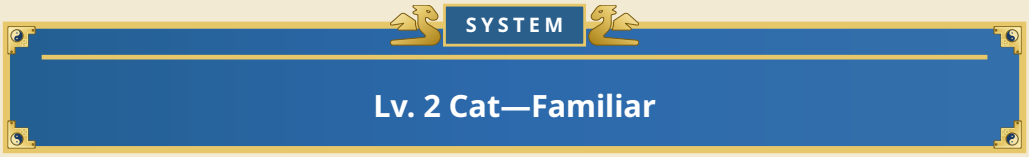
“Me?”

“Yeah. You know how our Lady Kim melts for her eldest son. She told me to get your permission, too, so put in a good word for me when we go inside later.”

“We’ll see.”

“What? You liked animals when you were little.”

I did. I still do, in fact. But this little thing sitting quietly in Hayeon’s palm was…



A little different.

Chapter 95

Heh heh heh. Success.

Hong Woojin smiled smugly. He was a veteran at monitoring his targets' every move and extracting every bit of information from them.

The information that Jin Taekyung's younger sister was crazy about animals—cats in particular—had proved especially useful.

"Meow-meow, answer me. You like being inside the house, don't you?"

The infiltration had been natural and successful. Inside the kitten's body, Hong Woojin let out a roar of joy.

"Miaowww."

"Ahh, so cute! Oppa[597], did you hear that just now? You heard it, right?"

"Yeah. I heard it."

"How can you be so indifferent to such a cute little creature? Are you even human?"

"Then what am I, a beast?"

The problem was Jin Taekyung.

Even the most emotionally dried-up person tended to soften in front of a cute animal, especially a tiny one, but…

"Move over a little. You're blocking the TV."

This guy had none of that. His sensitivity was drier than the Sahara Desert, and his younger sister, Jin Hayeon, grumbled.

"Good grief, there's a limit to how bleak a person can be. Right, Yeoreum?"

"Yeoreum?"

"Yeah. Born in summer, so Midsummer. Pretty, right?"

"Midsummer, my ass. Judging by the size, the kitten looks about three months old. That means it was born in late spring, so call it Late Spring or something."

"…Was that a comment or a fart? Anyway, this kitten's name is Yeoreum from today onward. Right, Yeoreum?"

"Mrowww."

As far as Hong Woojin was concerned, Jin Hayeon deserved most of the credit. Thanks to her, everything was going smoothly.

"Ahh! She answered! Yeoreum, you just answered your big sister, didn't you? Didn't you?"

"Miaow."

"Eek, my heart!"

---

[597] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man. Hayeon uses it for her brother, Taekyung.

Heh. What an easy one to handle. A few meows were all it took to make her lose her mind.

This is why high-school girls are… No, wait. It's because my choice of Familiar was excellent.

Hong Woojin was grinning contentedly when—

Jin Taekyung, who had been staring blankly at the TV, casually tossed out a remark.

"Isn't that one male?"

"Huh? Well, that…"

"We don't know yet, do we?"

"Come to think of it, I haven't checked."

"Let's take a look. We can find out."

Huh?

Things were taking a strange turn. His body might currently belong to a cat, but Hong Woojin was still a vigorous young man. As Jin Taekyung's large hand approached, a wave of shame suddenly washed over him.

That filthy bastard is going to look at my junk?

Strictly speaking, it wasn't Hong Woojin's body. They were different species, so naturally their anatomy was different as well.

However, Familiar magic made the caster and Familiar share everything. He couldn't help feeling disgusted.

Absolutely not!

Hong Woojin hurriedly burrowed into Jin Hayeon's arms.

"Mrowww."

"Oh my, I don't think she likes that."

"That's how the world works. Who gets to live doing only what they want?"

"But Yeoreum's a cat."

"Cats are the same. If you want warm feed and even a can of treats, you have to put up with this much."

What a lunatic. He was spouting utter nonsense just because he wanted to check a cat's sex. Grinding his teeth, Hong Woojin clung to his only hope, Jin Hayeon.

He rubbed his entire body against her arm and gave her a pitiful look. Her eyes slowly softened.

"What am I going to do? Yeoreum's so cute I could die."

"Yeah, it's cute. So let's take a look."

"Do it next time. You're scaring her."

"That's just your imagination."

"I'm telling you, Yeoreum doesn't like you, Oppa[598]."

The trick was to let out a whimper at exactly the right moment.

"Mnyaa. Mngh."

"See? I'm right, aren't I?"

"…Then I guess it can't be helped."

"Don't you dare manhandle the kitten. Kittens are sensitive, so you have to be careful with them."

Good. He had gotten past the immediate crisis. Jin Taekyung seemed like a lunatic who lived in his own world, but he was weak when it came to his family.

Having fully absorbed all the background information Sangdong Guild had given him, Hong Woojin thought he was one step ahead.

This is why information matters. You've already fallen right into my trap.

But there was one fact Hong Woojin had never imagined.

"Hey, Sis."

"Yeah?"

"Do you need more spending money?"

"…Are you trying to bribe me so you can have your way with our Yeoreum?"

"Yeah. A hundred thousand won[599]."

"Deal. But be gentle so she doesn't hate you too much, okay?"

"My wallet's on the desk in my room. Go get it."

"Eek!"

"Miaow?"

Jin Hayeon disappeared like a bullet. Hong Woojin let out a cry filled with disbelief.

You said she was so cute you could die! You called her our Yeoreum!

What a shameless little brat.

One minute she had acted ready to give Yeoreum her liver and gallbladder, and now she was abandoning "our Yeoreum" for a mere hundred thousand won[600]?

But he was given no time to lament the realities of capitalist society.

"Come on. Let's play."

Grab.

Jin Taekyung restrained all four of his limbs with lightning speed, a revolting smile on his face.

Hong Woojin screamed desperately.

Let go! Let go, you son of a bitch!

---

[598] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man. Hayeon uses it for her brother, Taekyung.

[599] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

[600] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

"Hiss! Hissss!"

The kitten's fur stood on end as he hissed, catching the attention of his only hope as she rummaged through Jin Taekyung's wallet.

"Oppa[601]!"

"Yeah, take another hundred thousand won[602]."

"Thanks!"

Hey! Hey!

His only hope had fallen and become a slave to capitalism!

Before the shock had even worn off, Jin Taekyung's hot breath swept over him.

"Our Yeoreum, shall we take a look at your little peepee?"

At that desperate, life-or-death moment—

Sever Link!

"Miaowww!"

With a sorrowful cry, all the strength drained out of the kitten's body.

Then Hong Woojin opened his eyes somewhere dark and let out a breath.

"Puhack!"

Since starting work as a Hunter, he had handled around a hundred assignments, large and small, but this was the first time he had ever felt his life was in danger.

He looked down at his forearms, which were covered in goose bumps, and began to gag.

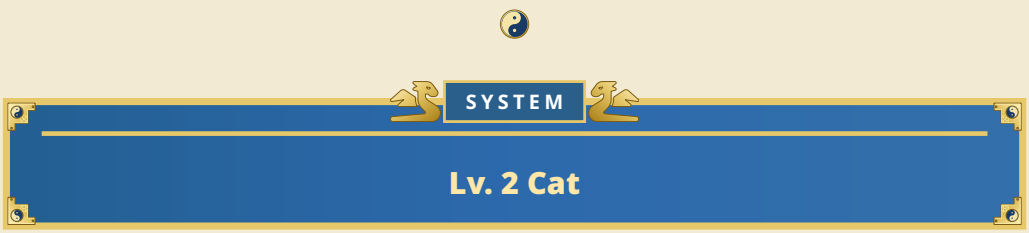
"Urgh."

His stomach churned, and his head throbbed.

It was a side effect of the sudden Link severance. Only after he gulped down the potion he had prepared in advance like cold water could Hong Woojin finally catch his breath.

"Jin Taekyung, that fucking bastard…"

It was the moment he first regretted ever accepting the assignment.



"There he goes."

[601] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man. Hayeon uses it for her brother, Taekyung.

[602] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

Clicking my tongue, I released the kitten. Was it even three months old? The little thing, smaller than my two palms put together, backed away with a bewildered look.

"Miaow."

Hayeon was leaving my room when she spotted what had happened.

"You didn't do anything mean to our Yeoreum, did you?"

"And you're the one who sold Yeoreum for 200,000 won[603]?"

"…Ahem. Ahem."

"Whatever. Good grief. Of all the things you could've picked up, you had to bring home that."

"What are you talking about? Look how cute she is."

"That's not what I meant… Never mind. Forget it."

The whole story was too long and complicated to explain piece by piece. Besides, I had no intention of telling her.

Imagine telling her that some sinister bastard had entered the body of a cat and was watching us. It was obvious how anxious she would become. My family couldn't find out about what was happening.

Besides, I was the one who had allowed it.

The reason I had let a Familiar into the house wasn't because Hayeon had asked or because Mom had given her permission.

It was because I wanted it.

I didn't know who had hired them, but even if I drove them off now, they would keep trying.

It didn't matter whether the Familiar took the form of an insect like last time or a cat like today.

What mattered was that I already knew what the Familiar was and could swat it away whenever I wanted.

They're definitely somewhere around here.

Within 500 meters[604] of the house. Somewhere inside that radius was a mage controlling the Familiar. If I shook him down, I was sure I'd find the connection.

First I'll punch him in the mouth. Then I'll ask questions.

He had illegally surveilled a civilian, so there was no way he could report me even if I beat him. Just thinking about teaching him a proper lesson made my fists itch.

How dare they snoop around my house?

---

[603] 200,000 Korean won is about $140 or €130.
[604] 500 meters is about 1,640 ft, or 0.31 mi.
[605] 300 million Korean won is about $210,000 or €190,000.

They had interrupted my first vacation in a long time, and thanks to these bastards, I had already spent well over 300 million won[605]. In every respect, this was a losing proposition.

I was watching TV with my face twisted into a scowl when Hayeon cautiously studied my expression and spoke.

“Oppa[606], are you mad?”

“No. What would I be mad about?”

“I’m sorry.”

“…What’s gotten into you? You’re starting to scare me.”

I wasn’t joking. I was more startled than when I had first discovered the Familiar. Since when could she say something like that?

I asked seriously.

“Are you sick?”

“No, it’s just…”

“Then are you hungry?”

“That’s not it…”

Just as Hayeon hesitated, about to say something, a stomach growled from somewhere.

It wasn’t mine. Mom had stepped out to run an errand.

“You’re hungry.”

“Mm, a little?”

“Right. You’re so hungry you’re starting to spout nonsense. You know where my wallet is, right? Order anything you want to eat.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. Up to a hundred thousand won[607].”

“Wow, now that you’re making money, you’ve gotten generous. Our Oppa[608].”

I never thought I’d live to hear her call me “our Oppa[609].” It was the first time I’d heard it since Hayeon had been in middle school, and it gave me goose bumps.

“You’re the Familiar, you little bastard!”

“What are you talking about? Anyway, I can order whatever I want as long as it’s under a hundred thousand won[610]?”

“Yeah. No, wait. Fine. Order everything you want.”

“What about the money left over?”

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[606] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man. Hayeon uses it for her brother, Taekyung.

[607] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

[608] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man. Hayeon uses it for her brother, Taekyung.

[609] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses for an older brother or a close older man. Hayeon uses it for her brother, Taekyung.

[610] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.

"…Did you leave your money with me?"

"The more, the better."

Her shamelessness left me dumbfounded, but at the same time, I was happy.

She had never once asked me for spending money. Judging by the clothes she wore and how she usually looked, she was far more modest than the kids her age I occasionally saw on the street.

What an old soul.

Come to think of it, Hayeon had been like that since she was little. She rarely cried, and she didn't often express her feelings honestly. Her current personality had only developed after she entered high school.

She ought to be allowed to act spoiled once in a while… She grew up too soon.

Maybe even far sooner than I did.

Was that why? None of her actions or words annoyed me in the slightest. If anything, I found her admirable, and I was happy.

"Fine. Take it all. Take everything."

"Really?"

"Yeah."

Hayeon beamed at my words.

"That's a relief. I almost felt bad for nothing."

"What's there to feel bad about?"

"I took three hundred thousand won[611] from your wallet earlier."

"…Huh?"

"But when you said I could have whatever was left after eating within the 100,000-won[612] limit, I felt better."

"Hold on. Didn't I tell you to take two hundred thousand won[613]?"

"It was an impulsive accident."

"…Don't you mean an impulsive crime?"

I take back what I said earlier.

The sight of her back as she hummed her way into her room couldn't have been more irritating.

The head of Sangdong Guild's Security Team frowned.

"A Cat Familiar?"

"Yes, I'm certain."

[611] 300,000 Korean won is about $210 or €190.
[612] 100,000 Korean won is about $71 or €65.
[613] 200,000 Korean won is about $140 or €130.

The person who answered in a firm voice was a member of the Security Team and the Guild's only Familiar mage. He was only a C-grade Hunter, but as a rare mental mage, he was also a core member of the Security Team.

"The target's younger sister is a cat fanatic. Hong Woojin took advantage of that opening perfectly."

"Can't you read the room? You're praising that bastard to my face?"

"I-I'm sorry."

"Team 1 Leader said Hong Woojin called and went ballistic, saying he nearly got exposed because of us."

"…"

"Come to think of it, that bastard is technically on our side, too. But can we afford to be outdone by a freelancer? Don't you know the Guild Master is taking a special interest in this?"

Six people had been assigned to the operation, including the Security Team Leader. One was the Familiar mage. Four were close-combat Hunters specializing in tracking and stealth. The last was the Security Team Leader himself, a B-grade Hunter.

"You seem to be misunderstanding something… We didn't come here just to dig up dirt on one C-grade Hunter."

The Security Team Leader glared menacingly at his team.

The Guild Master had personally ordered this operation. They had to produce results that went beyond the direct order, no matter what.

"Let's do this properly. This came straight from the Guild Master. Are you going to end here? You should get bonuses and promotions too."

The team members silently lowered their heads.

The person most desperate for a bonus and promotion was the Security Team Leader himself. The hysteria of a middle-aged family man whose retirement was slowly approaching was nothing new by this point.

"And you."

The Security Team Leader pointed at the Familiar mage.

"You do the cat, too."

"The cat? They already did that over there."

"What, then? Are you going to put on another pathetic act with a tiny Familiar you can't even control and die like last time?"

"…"

"Do as you're told. The girl's a cat fanatic, isn't she?"

If he was told to use a cat, then he had to use a cat. What choice did he have?

After the Security Team Leader stormed out, the Familiar mage immediately turned on his smartphone and began searching.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

> ### Cats for Adoption in Ilsan

“…Will they let me expense this?”

Chapter 96

Kim Junsu was a C-rank Hunter in Sangdong Guild's Security Team.

He didn't have an ounce of talent for elemental magic, but fortunately, he had awakened as a rare mental mage and was doing pretty well for himself.

Except I can never go home.

What good was owning a house of more than 330 square meters?[614] As Sangdong Guild's only Familiar mage, he never ran out of work.

Raid teams at least got to go home after running a Gate. The Security Team had no such luxury. They had to stay up all night in a different hideout each time.

"Junsu, did you pull an all-nighter?"

"Yes."

A Security Team colleague clicked his tongue at Kim Junsu's hollow-eyed face. He was the one person who had stayed behind to protect their valuable Familiar mage.

"You've got it rough. How does that bastard not set one foot outside?"

"Tell me about it. We've been watching him for days, and he's only gone out twice. Twice. Once to a real-estate office in Goyang, and once to the Ilsan Store."

"This is why smokers make better targets. At least they come outside for a cigarette."

They had acquired a new cat to use as a Familiar and waited all night at the entrance to the apartment building, but the target hadn't budged.

The only incident had come when the cat, tired of waiting, started yowling and nearly got chased away by a security guard.

"Peace Guild? It looked pretty small. Do they even go on raids?"

"They're on vacation right now."

"Vacation?"

"Yeah. A buddy of mine in Team 2 is watching the other Peace Guild members, and he said they're all taking time off."

"Ah… How are things going over there?"

"They pulled out yesterday. There was one woman and one middle-aged man, but it ended quickly. Judging by the Team Leader's reaction, it seems like they turned up something over there, but I don't know the details."

"Phew. We should just do enough to get by and pull out, too."

His colleague gave Kim Junsu a pitying look as he heaved a deep sigh.

"There has to be a reason they specially assigned the Guild's only Familiar mage, right?"

---

[614] 330 square meters is about 3,550 square feet.

“He’s still only a C-rank Hunter. Don’t you think this is going a little overboard?”

“What can we do? When they say jump, we jump. If the Team Leader keeps riding you like he did yesterday, just put up with it.”

“He could stand to ease up. This would’ve been over ages ago if he’d talked things through with that Hong Woojin guy and cooperated properly.”

“He wants to show off for the Guild Master. ‘Our Security Team is far better than Hong Woojin. Look at my outstanding leadership.‘ Besides, it’s almost time for the second-half personnel reshuffle. No wonder the Team Leader’s sweating bullets.”

“…This is driving me insane.”

“Sure is.”

Kim Junsu wanted to tear his hair out, but he held himself back. If he did, the hair that had only just begun sprouting like fresh spring shoots might come right out.

Ah, the doctor said stress makes hair loss worse.

The doctor was a civilian who couldn’t even use the simple Light magic, but if he could give Kim Junsu a full head of hair, Junsu would worship him as Jesus.

Come to think of it, maybe I haven’t lost much hair today.

Kim Junsu was cautiously reaching up to feel the crown of his head when—

“Target confirmed. Target confirmed. Moving!”

A low but urgent voice came through the radio.

The two men in the room—and even the Security Team Leader, who had been snoring in the next room—bolted upright.

Slurp.

The Team Leader wiped the drool from his mouth and shouted, “Hey! Kim Junsu!”

Damn it. I haven’t even had breakfast yet.

Using Familiar magic makes my hair fall out again!

Fuck this. The moment my contract ends, I’m quitting the Guild.

Swallowing back his tears, Kim Junsu drew up his mana. His head grew hot as his consciousness was sucked inward.

Faithful servant, answer my call. Link!

Whoosh!

The next moment, a kitten lying beneath a car snapped its eyes open.

“Myaow.”

I stopped walking.

A black ball of fur had suddenly popped out with a cry.

SYSTEM

Lv. 2 Cat—Familiar

"…"

Another cat. Did these bastards have no creativity at all?

Well, one thing was different. This one's fur was pitch-black.

"Miaow. Miaowww."

The kitten approached with a surprisingly bold stride for something so young, then rubbed its whole body against my slipper. Whoever was controlling it clearly knew how to work a club.

Man. I'm not into getting attention this way.

But the appearance of this new Familiar allowed me to make a new guess.

These guys aren't working together, are they?

Two conspicuous Familiars, both in the form of cats, appearing a day apart? It was hardly a good approach. If anything, it felt like someone had hurriedly copied the first attempt.

"Meow!"

The cat cried as if demanding my attention, and I let out a quiet laugh.

"You little thing. You're cute."

Should I take it with me or not…?

My mind was racing when—

"That cat's pretty affectionate. Is it yours, sir?"

A man approached, dragging his slippers. He looked to be in his early forties, with an utterly ordinary face. His stretched-out T-shirt and soccer shorts stained with ramen broth gave him an approachable air.

"No. I think it's a stray, but it suddenly started acting affectionate."

"Wow, this is totally one of those. A dog-cat."[615]

"Exactly. Just like yesterday. I guess the cats in this neighborhood are pretty affectionate."

"Yesterday?"

"Yeah. I picked one up yesterday too. Another dog-cat."[616]

"Well, that's something."

The man took a drag from his half-smoked cigarette.

"Times like this make you think even animals are brought together with people for a reason. It must think you'd make a good owner. That's why it's cozying up to you."

---

[615] A Korean term for a cat that acts like a dog—friendly and affectionate.

[616] A Korean term for a cat that acts like a dog—friendly and affectionate.

"Come on, what do you mean, a good owner? I think it just has this kind of personality."

"Is that so? Hey, hey, come here."

The cat didn't budge at the man's beckoning.

No, it burrowed between my legs instead.

"Well, look at this one. Young as it is, it already knows how to pick its people."

I only smiled without saying anything, so the man asked, "So, are you going to keep it?"

"I'm not sure. I have something urgent to take care of. If it's still here when I get back, maybe I'll look after it for a few days."

"Who knows if it'll still be here by then. Right, Nabi?"[617]

"Mrow."

"I won't be long. I'm just going to the real-estate office right over there."

"Really? Oh, come to think of it, I've never seen you before, young man. I've lived here a long time, so I know just about everyone. Since you're going to a real-estate office, are you moving into the neighborhood?"

"I live somewhere else. I only come by once in a while to see my family. I just have something to take care of at the real-estate office."

"Ah…"

Phew.

His last breath of smoke scattered in the wind. The man flicked his cigarette butt onto the ground and said, "Well, look at me, holding up a busy man. You're not offended, are you?"

"Not at all."

"Then that's good. If we meet again, let's say hello. We're neighbors, after all."

I answered, "Yes. We're neighbors."

"Then I'll be off. The weather's nice, so I should take a lap around the neighborhood."

The man gave me a good-natured smile and started walking. I watched his retreating back for a moment as he moved away with a loose, swinging gait.

He's a good actor.

"Meow."

Right. You're here, too.

The moment I left the house, I met two actors. Actors wearing the guises of a stray cat and a neighbor.

"I'll be back soon, so wait here quietly, okay?"

The cat tilted its head as if it had no idea what I was talking about.

---

[617] *Nabi* means "butterfly" in Korean and is also a common name for a cat.

But I knew. It had understood me, and it would still be sitting here even if several hours passed.

And there was one more thing.

There weren't any Hunters living in the building next to ours.

Just as I thought. They aren't working together.

The appearance of the two actors was enough to turn my guess into certainty.

My steps grew even lighter as I headed toward the real-estate office in front of the house.

Late that morning, a middle-aged man in shabby clothes dragged his slippers along while humming to himself. He looked like someone you could see anywhere.

The moment he rounded the corner, he pulled out a cigarette and stuck it between his lips.

"Let's see. Where's my lighter…"

His hand rummaged slowly through his pocket, but his eyes darted around.

Once he had confirmed that no one was nearby, he pulled out something other than a lighter: a miniature radio.

"How was my acting? Maybe I should've become an actor instead of a Hunter. Seems like I'm better at acting than fighting."

"It's me, the Team Leader."

Plop.

The cigarette fell from his mouth. His now-free lips moved soundlessly.

Fuck. I'm screwed.

Kim Gwondong, a C-rank Hunter in the Security Team, hurriedly collected himself and answered.

"Ah, yes, Team Leader."

"Kim Gwondong's pretty good at acting, huh? You could quit the Guild and go to Hollywood."

"I-I'm sorry."

"Don't get scared. That was a compliment. Anyway, how's the target? He didn't catch on, did he?"

"I don't think so."

The Team Leader had already heard the conversation through Kim Junsu, but there was a simple reason he was asking again.

A cat's eyes could not capture everything about the target clearly.

"Are you sure? One hundred percent?"

"Ninety percent."

"You little shit, is ninety percent certain? At times like this, you're supposed to say it confidently and go for it."

"It's dangerous to jump to conclusions."

Kim Gwondong cursed the Team Leader inwardly.

What good would that do? If something goes wrong later, you'll be the first one to rip me a new asshole.

He had to leave himself an escape route. Kim Gwondong's ninety percent would only be complete once the Team Leader supplied the remaining ten.

"That's exactly the attitude I like to see. You know what to do next, right?"

The pleasure in the Team Leader's voice signaled that they had finally reached one hundred percent.

Kim Gwondong subtly changed direction to avoid a resident approaching in the distance.

"Yes. I'll circle the area naturally and keep watch."

"Right. Report immediately if anything unusual happens."

"Yes."

"Keep up the good work, then."

No one overheard the conversation, which lasted just over a minute.

This time, Kim Gwondong took out a real lighter and lit his cigarette. He inhaled deeply.

"Fuck. Lung cancer's going to kill me before a monster does."

The Security Team Leader got busy. There were three external surveillance personnel in total. He had to give instructions to the other two and make sure every precaution was taken.

"Number One."

"Number One here."

"You were listening on the all-team channel, right? What's the situation with the real-estate office the target is heading to?"

"There are two in the nearby shopping district. We've installed magical eavesdropping Equipment in both."

"Good. Where's the target?"

“We haven’t seen him yet… Ah, there he is. He’s approaching from about 300 meters away.”[618]

“Leave your position. We already installed the Equipment, so there’s no need to make contact for no reason.”

“Yes. I’ll report immediately if anything unusual happens.”

“Okay. Number Two?”

“Standing by at my current position.”

A deep voice came over the radio.

The Security Team Leader nodded at the reply from another team member concealed in a nearby shop.

“That bastard might veer off and take another route, so keep a close eye on him.”

“Yes.”

Four C-rank Hunters specializing in stealth and tracking, plus a Familiar mage.

They lacked combat power, but every one of them was a veteran with extensive experience in this field.

It’s overkill for one C-rank Hunter.

At first, he had been somewhat wary. The Guild Master had given them a special warning about the target.

They said he cleared a B-rank Gate alone, I think.

But the more information he gathered about the man, the more he watched him, the more he felt that was not the case at all. The fact that the information had come from Im Changsoo finally put an end to his doubts.

That good-for-nothing bastard made it all up because he didn’t want to get beaten to death.

An ordinary C-rank Hunter you could find anywhere.

In his eyes, that was all Jin Taekyung was.

Beep.

“Target entering the real-estate office.”

A report came over the radio from the team member keeping watch.

Sangdong Guild’s Security Team went on full alert.

[618] 300 meters is about 980 feet.

Chapter 97

"Oh my, welcome!"

An ajumma[619] who looked to be in her forties greeted me in a nasal singsong.

Maybe it was because the real-estate office was so close to home, but she looked vaguely familiar, like someone I'd passed once or twice on my way home.

"A young man! What would you like to drink? Coffee? Yulmu tea?[620] Cola?"

"Coffee, please."

"Black, creamer, or…"

"Black."

"Well, look at you. A young bachelor who knows how to drink his coffee."

I let her rapid-fire chatter go in one ear and out the other as I took a seat. There was something else I needed to pay more attention to than the talkative real-estate ajumma.[621]

This is…

The familiar energy flowing through the real-estate office.

Mana.

Eavesdropping magic?

There was almost no chance it was security magic installed by the owner. Who would put an expensive magic product in a real-estate office instead of their home?

The people watching me had clearly made preparations in advance.

Well, I expected as much.

They were using Familiars, after all. Eavesdropping magic was nothing by comparison.

The question was how many of them there were and where they were hiding…

"Here you go. One coffee."

I accepted the cup with a polite smile.

"Ah, thank you."

I meant it sincerely.

After all, she was about to tell me where their base was.

"So, what brings our handsome boss here?"

"I'm looking for a place."

---

[619] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

[620] Yulmu tea is a sweet Korean grain beverage made from roasted Job's tears.

[621] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

The eavesdropping magic transmitted their voices with perfect clarity. Kim Junsu, who had briefly deactivated his Familiar magic, exchanged looks with another team member and the Security Team Leader.

“Didn’t that bastard go to a real-estate office recently, too?”

“Yes. He went to one in Goyang. That was before we were assigned to him, so the Team 1 Leader got the information from Hong Woojin and passed it on to us.”

“Junsu’s right. We went to the real-estate office afterward and dug around a little. Apparently, he even put down a deposit.”

“How much does he have in his account right now?”

The Security Team already knew Jin Taekyung’s account balance inside and out.

At the Security Team Leader’s question, a team member quickly pulled out a tablet and brought up the report.

“About 3.7 billion won.[622] Three billion won[623] of that will go toward buying the new house.”

“Are you sure he’s going to buy it?”

“We even heard that he’s planning to set a date with the owner and sign the contract soon, so he definitely intends to purchase it. We looked into it, and apparently it’s the neighborhood where the target lived as a child. It seems to have some special meaning to him.”

“I see…”

The Security Team Leader frowned.

The man was about to pour most of his fortune into a new house. So why was he looking into another house in this neighborhood now?

His Guild is in Bucheon, too.

Whatever he was thinking, the whole thing left him feeling uneasy.

“Hey, turn up the volume a little.”

“Yes, sir.”

The conversation continued to flow into the three men’s ears.

“What kind of conditions are you looking for?”

“Either monthly rent or a jeonse lease.[624]”

“I do have a few, but… as you know, this neighborhood straddles a safety zone, so it’s a little expensive.”

“That’s fine. I’m a Hunter.”

“Oh my, you’re a Hunter? No wonder you’re so fit. What rank are you? Ah, am I being nosy asking something like that?”

“Nothing special. It’s not very high. C-rank.”

---

[622] 3.7 billion won is about $2.6 million or €2.4 million.

[623] Three billion won is about $2.1 million or €1.9 million.

[624] *Jeonse* is a Korean lease arrangement in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent.

“Oh my, oh my. You must make good money. Can I feel your arm? Oh-ho-ho!”

“Ha-ha. Show me some good listings and I’ll think about it. Actually, show me everything you’ve got. Jeonse,[625] places for sale, all of it. If I find something I like, I’ll just buy it.”

The three men listening were dumbfounded.

“That bastard’s having the time of his life.”

“Can you blame him? He lived as an F-rank Hunter, then after his reawakening, big chunks of money started rolling in. Of course his ego’s through the roof.”

“Hmm, true. That’s the age for it.”

They all knew from experience. The feeling of stepping into a new world.

Luxury goods that had once been too expensive even to look at suddenly seemed laughable, and people began looking at you differently.

“That bastard’s right in the middle of it.”

“‘If I find something I like, I’ll buy it,‘ my ass. Once you pay the balance on the house you already contracted for, your account will barely cover a jeonse deposit,[626] you idiot.”

“Still, I’m jealous. What does he eat to have hair that thick?”

Watching Jin Taekyung’s childish, cocky behavior was pathetic, but a quiet laugh escaped them anyway.

Before they knew it, the three men had relaxed. Their ears were still open, but they felt as if they were listening to a radio broadcast.

“How about this place? Around five hundred million won[627] for a jeonse lease?[628] Considering it’s in a safety zone, it’s listed well below market price.”

“Not bad. Are there any others?”

“Of course there are. There’s another listing two buildings over from the one I just showed you… Oh, this one was taken recently. It was monthly rent, but the terms were exceptionally good.”

“Oh, really?”

“Yeah. If you’d come a few days earlier, young man, you could’ve snagged it. The place wasn’t well maintained, but the rent was cheap. Of course, if you have money, remodeling can solve that problem.”

“That’s a shame.”

---

[625] *Jeonse* is a Korean lease arrangement in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent.

[626] *Jeonse* is a Korean lease arrangement in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent.

[627] Five hundred million won is about $360,000 or €320,000.

[628] *Jeonse* is a Korean lease arrangement in which the tenant pays a large lump-sum deposit instead of monthly rent.

“I’m disappointed too. Some scary-looking man came by and spoke to me in this commanding tone. Did he think he’d left a house in my care or something? I’d much rather hand it over to a young, handsome bachelor, you know. Right?”

“Ugh, sounds like a total boomer.”

“I thought he might be a gangster, so I couldn’t so much as squeak. The smell of an old bachelor was practically pouring off him. I thought I was going to die. Ho-ho-ho.”

Grrrind.

Teeth ground beside them. Kim Junsu and the other team member fought back the laughter threatening to burst out.

It’s the Team Leader.

Definitely the Team Leader.

A gangster-like impression and the smell of an old bachelor. Just hearing that much was enough to identify the Security Team Leader.

His expression was so frightening that there was even a rumor that when he first joined Sangdong Guild, the interviewer had been too scared to look any further and hired him on the spot.

“Has that ajumma[629] lost her mind…?”

The Team Leader ground his teeth and whipped around. The other two men, red-faced from holding back their laughter, hurriedly lowered their heads.

“You two look like you’re having a hard time holding it in.”

“Oh, no, sir.”

“Nothing of the sort, sir.”

They tried desperately to deny it, but the Team Leader was already thoroughly offended. He rose from his seat.

For a single man in his mid-forties, the words *old bachelor* touched on a subject that absolutely should not be touched.

“I’m going to the sauna to wash off this old-bachelor smell, so have the transcript ready for me to read as soon as I get back.”

“What?”

Kim Junsu and the other team member were dumbfounded.

A C-rank Hunter showing off at a real-estate office and a scatterbrained ajumma.[630] Why would anyone write up a transcript of their completely unremarkable conversation?

“Team Leader, it’s all being saved automatically…”

“Prepare a full-page A4 statement of your individual opinions, too. He’s an important target, so we should gather the team’s input.”

---

[629] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

[630] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

"…"

"…"

Since when had he ever asked for their opinions? And how could it make sense for the Team Leader to go to a sauna while they were dealing with such an important target?

Their expressions twisted at the narrow-minded superior's petty retaliation.

"Didn't you hear me? Repeat the order back. Execute!"

"…Yes."

"…Execute."

"You bastards have gotten way too lax. You treat your Team Leader like dog shit."

The Security Team Leader glared at his subordinates, snorted angrily, and stormed out of the room.

Bang!

The apartment's front door slammed shut. The two men left behind immediately spat out everything they had been holding in.

"Man, fuck this."

"Isn't this taking things way too far?"

"Why is he taking it out on us because he has an ugly face and can't get married?"

"Is his face the only problem? That ajumma[631] said he spoke in a commanding tone. His personality's rotten, too."

"I'm so damn sick of this. I can't keep doing this."

"Ah, I really can't afford to get stressed out. It'll make even more of my hair fall out."

Kim Junsu muttered in a voice thick with tears and felt the top of his head. He couldn't be sure, but it seemed like at least ten hairs had fallen out in the last few moments.

"What do we do about the transcript and the statements?"

"What do you think? If you don't want to watch the Team Leader throw a fit, you have to write them. Want to go to the hospital and get a medical statement?"

"…"

"Just slap something together. I'll cover for you and say you couldn't write yours because you were using Familiar magic."

After heaving deep sighs, the two men began cursing the Team Leader in earnest.

All the while, the conversation continued through the transmitter.

"It's nice. It faces south, so it gets plenty of sunlight. What about the building next to it? Don't tell me that one's gone, too?"

[631] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

“Huh? No, it’s still available. Business has been slow lately, so the places that went recently were… Wait, young man.”

“Yes?”

“Your arm is really firm. Goodness, just look at those muscles and veins.”

“…”

“Young man, come again! Come twice!”

I left the real-estate office with the ajumma’s[632] regretful farewell behind me.

Goose bumps had risen all over the arm her hand had just brushed.

Whether it’s an ajumma[633] or an ajusshi,[634] people who grow old without growing up are all alike when it comes to hitting on younger people.

I left as if fleeing her sticky gaze, but I had already accomplished what I’d gone there to do, so I had no regrets about leaving.

Confirm the listings that were recently sold or leased.

Today was exactly five days after the raid with Im Changsoo.

In other words, the surveillance team couldn’t have been assigned to me more than five days ago.

I tried to act and ask about it indirectly without making it obvious, but…

Knowing that eavesdropping magic was in place, every word and action had been deliberate. I wanted to come across as an unremarkable C-rank Hunter packed full of arrogance and extravagance.

Whether they fell for it or not was another matter.

My conversation with the real-estate ajumma[635] had given me an important clue. I silently muttered the addresses I had memorized in advance.

Building 5, Unit 901. Building 4, Unit 302. Building 3, Unit 202.

These were the three listings that had changed hands in the past five days.

I had used our house as the center point and set the range at a maximum of five hundred meters[636]—the distance Familiar magic could reach.

The watchers were definitely somewhere within that range.

The problem is how to find them.

My goal wasn’t to drive them away. I wanted to catch them, beat the hell out of them, and find out who was behind them.

If I went after the wrong place too soon, they might catch on and run.

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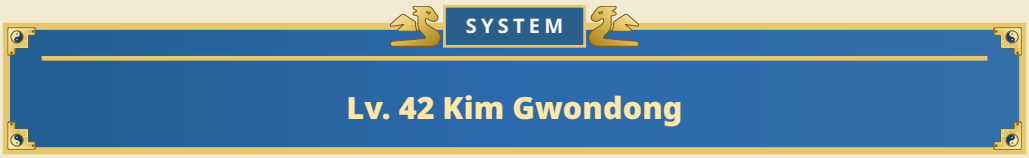
[632] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.
[633] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.
[634] *Ajusshi* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged man.
[635] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.
[636] Five hundred meters is about 1,640 ft.

They could be hiding in a car, so I should check the parking lot too.

Searching the nearby homes would tip them off, but I could search the parking lot without looking suspicious.

All I had to do was pretend to take a walk while sweeping the area with Qi Sense.

Game over.



“Oh, we meet again.”

Just like this guy.

I greeted Kim Gwondong when he called out to me.

“Indeed. We meet again.”

“You said you were going to the real-estate office. Finished already?”

“I just asked a few questions. But when I actually went there and looked into it, the house prices weren’t exactly cheap. I ran right back out.”

“That’s this neighborhood for you. Still, you’re doing well for yourself, young man. At your age, all I did was sit at home and eat my parents’ food.”

“Doing well? Ha-ha.”

If he knew what real ability looked like, he’d faint.

Kim Gwondong laughed along, unaware of my thoughts, then spoke.

“Well, I should get going. I need to walk to the park over there and back.”

“You must like taking walks.”

“Huh? It’s not that I do it because I like it. I do it because I need to. You’ll have a hard time too once you reach my age.”

He conspicuously waved his thin arms and legs.

To all appearances, he was just a scrawny, potbellied middle-aged man.

He certainly looks like a civilian.

Anyone else would have fallen for it completely.

But there was no such thing as a Level 42 civilian.

Probably a C-rank Hunter. Judging by his build, he likely specializes in stealth and pursuit.

Once you knew someone was a Hunter, there was plenty you could infer.

I said goodbye to Kim Gwondong.

“Then I’ll see you next time.”

“Maybe you will, maybe you won’t. Ha-ha.”

Well, I definitely wanted to see him.

Of course, when that happened, I wouldn't be parting from him with a smile and a laugh like I was now. I wanted to knock him flat right then and there, but it wasn't time yet.

I gave him a slight bow and turned to leave when his voice came from behind me.

"Oh, right. That cat seemed awfully smart. I saw it on my way over, and it was still there."

He had even given me a friendly reminder not to forget to pick up my Familiar.

And just as he said, the cat was waiting for me in the same spot as before.

"Meow."

Right. Hyung's[637] *here, you punk.*

[637] *Hyung* is what a man calls an older brother or an older man he is close to.

Chapter 98

Hong Woojin regretted it.

I didn't think this through.

The intrusion itself had gone perfectly. He had approached the target's cat-loving younger sister and won her heart with a pair of pitiful yet sparkling eyes.

The problem was…

"What does our Yeoreum eat to be this cute? Hmm? Hmm-hmm?"

Meow.

"Yeoreum, why do you keep trying to get out the door? Stay here and play with Sis."

Meow.

"Eek, you're so cute!"

Hiss! Hissssss!

"Oh no, is Yeoreum mad? I'm sorry. Did Sis pet you too much? Okay, I'll stay still, so play on the bed, all right?"

This damn younger sister had absolutely no intention of letting him out. Thanks to her, he had spent more than a day and a half trapped in Jin Hayeon's room.

I should've gone with a dog.

If he had been a dog, getting inside wouldn't have been this easy. But once he was in, he wouldn't have been practically held captive, either. At the very least, they would have taken him out for walks.

This is getting me nowhere.

Swept up by a sense of crisis, Hong Woojin attempted to escape.

Let's see who wins—you or me!

He had begun with that fierce resolve, but then…

Scritch, scritch-scritch-scritch.

"…"

Meow. Myaaaaaow.

"…"

His first attempt failed. He scratched desperately at the door and even yowled as loudly as he could, but Jin Hayeon didn't react even once.

She wasn't even wearing earphones. She simply continued working through her workbook with a fierce look in her eyes and swift movements of her hands.

So this is what it means to be in the top 0.01 percent nationwide.

He had seen it in the initial investigation report. Ever since middle school, she had routinely ranked first or second in her entire school and had earned countless awards in academic competitions. It was hard to forget a record like that.

Only today did Hong Woojin understand why.

Sitting at her desk, she displayed a truly terrifying level of concentration.

Someone like this would make the perfect mage… No, that's not the point.

He continued trying everything he could to disrupt her studies. He pawed at her feet without pause and kept acting cute.

But Jin Hayeon's response was simple.

"Big sis is studying right now. Don't bother me."

She pulled her feet up onto the chair and sat cross-legged, putting them completely out of reach of his tiny body.

That was the limit of being a kitten.

This operation has failed.

Since his plan to disrupt her studies had gone up in smoke, he had no choice but to play his final card. It would deal a serious blow to his human dignity, but this was no time to be picky.

Let's see if you ignore this, too.

Sssssssss.

The pristine white duvet turned yellow.

When nature called, it was best to take care of both kinds of business at once. Having finished both simultaneously, Hong Woojin made a solemn decision.

Fine. Since things have come to this, I might as well do it properly. Like a professional.

He rolled over and over.

It had been five years since he started using Familiar magic. This was the first time he had ever sunk this low.

He kept brainwashing himself.

I'm a professional. I'm a professional. I'm a professional…

A little while later, Jin Hayeon noticed a strange smell and turned around.

By then, it was all over.

Meow.

A duvet stained with urine and feces, and a kitten likewise covered in filth.

"Eek, Yeoreum!"

Startled, Jin Hayeon moved quickly. She pulled off the dirty duvet, then carefully grabbed the kitten by the scruff and lifted it up.

"What are you doing going to the bathroom here when your litter box is right there? We need to wash our Yeoreum."

Yes, go to the door! The door!

This was the moment he had been waiting for.

Even though he was covered in filth and dangling from the hand of a girl who wasn't even twenty, Hong Woojin was filled with joy.

Click.

The door was opening!

The living room he hadn't seen since yesterday came into view!

Meow! Myaaaow!

"That's strange. Why does it seem so happy?"

Jin Hayeon tilted her head.

That was when the front door opened with the familiar electronic tones of someone entering the passcode.

"I'm ho—… What is that?"

"Where have you been—… What's that?"

The siblings stared at each other in bewilderment.

More precisely, they stared at the creatures in each other's hands.

Meow.

Myaow.

The two cats exchanged equally bewildered looks.

That's Hong Woojin?

That guy is the Sangdong Guild's amateur?

And then came the next thought.

Why is he covered in shit from head to toe?

Ah, fuck.

It was the moment the last shred of Hong Woojin's human dignity came crashing down.

"He got poop all over the duvet?"

"Yeah. I guess he had an accident while I was studying for a bit."

An accident, my ass.

Hayeon had kept him in her room, petting and cuddling him nonstop, so he'd put his brain to work trying to escape. That was all.

Myaow…

The cat—no, there were two of them now, so I supposed I should call them by their names.

Anyway, Yeoreum let out a feeble cry, and Hayeon asked worriedly, "He's been listless for a while."

"Hmm. That can happen."

I couldn't say for sure, but his self-loathing had to be off the charts.

He had run into both a fellow professional and his surveillance target while covered in shit.

"Don't worry too much. Cats hate getting wet, you know."

"Is that why? No, he didn't even resist when I washed him earlier. He was completely docile."

"Oh, really?"

"I don't know if it's just my imagination, but he seems kind of out of it. Maybe he knows he made a mess and feels sorry?"

Our Yeoreum had a serious case of post-nut clarity.

I swallowed my laughter and said, "Who knows? Anyway, what are you going to do about the duvet? You'll have to change the sheets, too."

"It's fine. It was an animal, not a person. What's the big deal?"

They said a thoughtlessly thrown stone could kill a frog.

This was exactly that kind of situation. Hayeon's offhand remark turned into a dagger and plunged into someone's heart.

Flinch.

The kitten trembled violently in silence, unable to even cry out.

Meanwhile, the other one was having the time of its life.

Purr. Prrrr.

The black cat made happy noises as it rubbed its face against my leg over and over, and Hayeon gazed at it with utter adoration.

"Where did you bring him from?"

"The entrance to the apartment complex."

"Is he a stray?"

"I guess so. He was alone."

"What? Then his mother might be nearby. You're supposed to watch a kitten for about a day before bringing it home."

"Some man told me he'd been crying alone since yesterday."

"Oh, then he doesn't have a mother."

Flinch!

Its purring and attempts to act cute stopped dead. Without realizing it, Hayeon had scored two kills, and she smiled brightly.

"There, there. You don't have a mother, either. It's okay. From today on, Sis will be your mommy."

"…"

For my little sister, she certainly had a talent for screwing people over with a smile.

The black cat seemed torn between professional duty and the cheap shot at his mom, but soon accepted reality.

Meow.

The sight of it acting cute for its mother's enemy was downright pitiful.

That's the hardship of being a working stiff.

Watching them, I suddenly thought of Mom.

"Where's Mom?"

"I don't know. She went out for an important appointment."

"An appointment?"

"Yeah. She's been going out a lot lately."

What's going on?

Mom had been leaving the house frequently these days. Now that she had some free time after quitting her job, was she finally finding a life of her own?

Come to think of it, she had been acting strange.

Sometimes she would sit there looking as though she had something to say. Other times, she would jump whenever I suddenly spoke to her.

Something had definitely changed around Mom.

She'll tell me when the time is right.

My mother was the person I loved and trusted most in this world. As always, all I could do was trust her and wait.

Of course, listening to her and talking things over at the right time was also a child's duty.

"What are you thinking about so hard?"

"It's nothing. By the way, aren't you going out?"

"What? You sound like you want me to leave."

"Not exactly."

"Hmm. Suspicious. You're not planning to bring a girlfriend over, are you?"

"…"

I wish I had a girlfriend to bring over.

My expression must have revealed my thoughts, because Hayeon hesitated.

"Ah, I'm sorry."

"Don't apologize. It makes me twice as pathetic."

"I'm really sorry."

"You're doing this on purpose, aren't you?"

"Come to think of it, I have some books to return to the library."

She sprinted into her room, threw on her backpack, and came back out at the speed of light.

The front door slammed shut, and the house fell silent.

She really went and gouged out a single man's heart.

A corner of my chest felt hollow, but the stage I had been waiting for had finally been set.

This was a problem I needed to deal with while my family was out of the house, if possible.

Myaow.

Meow.

The two cats, one black and one white, crept toward me and began circling.

Bright eyes. Perked-up ears.

I left the Familiars, who were dying to learn more about me, behind and stepped onto the balcony.

The first thing I saw was the parking lot, where hundreds of cars were lined up.

The parking lot is clear.

Before returning home, I had carried the Familiar in my arms and taken a lap around the apartment complex. To everyone else, I probably looked like an idler out for a walk on a pleasant day.

My real purpose had been to check the vehicles.

The result was nothing suspicious.

Then it has to be one of those apartments.

That confirmed the watchers had made one of the recently sold or leased apartments their base. I recalled the information I had obtained from the real-estate office once more.

Building 5, Unit 901. Building 4, Unit 302. Building 3, Unit 202.

Coincidentally, all three were positioned around our apartment, forming a ring. Their windows also overlooked the building entrances, making them ideal for surveillance.

The watchers could have been in any one of them.

The question is which one they're hiding in…

They were cautious enough to use a Familiar instead of magical Equipment to avoid being discovered.

If I approached recklessly, I would lose them. To make a definite capture, I had no choice but to throw out equally substantial bait.

Time to get started.

Swish. Rustle.

First, I drew every curtain in the house. Though it was the middle of the day, the living room grew dim. Standing in its center, I reached into my pocket.

Inventory open. Mana-detection Equipment.

At the same time, my hand closed around a lump of metal half the size of my palm.

As its name suggested, it was Equipment that could detect mana. I had paid twenty

million won[638] for it at the Store.

Next step: search.

I carefully swept through the house with the detection Equipment. After confirming that no mana was being detected inside, I took out my smartphone and called someone.

Beep. Beep. Click.

The call connected, and the other person answered.

“Hello?”

I replied, “It’s me, Jin Taekyung.”

The two Familiars watched me without even seeming to breathe.

The moment Kim Junsu opened his eyes, he shouted.

“He’s here! He’s here!”

The Security Team members, who had been huddled together writing their assessments, jumped in surprise.

“What?”

“Who’s here? Our Team Leader?”

“Or could it be…”

Kim Junsu nodded at the team member who had trailed off.

“The target. This bastard reeks of something rotten.”

“Seriously?”

“Yes. I got a bad feeling when he drew all the curtains as soon as the house was empty, and then he even used detection Equipment to inspect the inside.”

That wasn’t something an ordinary C-rank Hunter would do, especially while on vacation.

Everyone in the room swallowed hard.

“Th-then what?”

“He pulled out his phone and made a call.”

“A call? To whom?”

“I don’t know.”

Kim Junsu furrowed his brow.

“The call was so short that it didn’t even last three minutes. But more than that, I could tell he was being extremely careful about how he addressed the other person.”

“That’s enough. We’ll report it up the chain and have them pull that bastard’s call records.”

[638] Twenty million Korean won is about $14,000 or €13,000 at the project conversion rates.

“Right. Was there anything else?”

“Of course there was. Do you know what he said?”

Ahem. After clearing his throat, he lowered his voice.

“The plan is proceeding without a hitch. Yes, yes. The Sangdong Guild hasn’t noticed anything yet. I have the item with me.”

The team members listening slapped their knees.

“This is it!”

“We finally got something!”

“Wow, I just got chills. What is he, some kind of secret agent?”

At that moment, Kim Gwondong, who had been listening quietly, suddenly spoke.

“Junsu, didn’t that bastard say he had some kind of item?”

“Good observation.”

Kim Jinsoo smiled meaningfully.

“That guy has a USB.”

Chapter 99

The Security Team Leader received a phone call just after finishing up at the sauna.

“Team Leader, it’s me, Kim Gwondong.”

“Yeah. You finish the transcript and assessment?”

“No, sir. That’s not it…”

“You little shit. I cut you some slack because you’re the most senior one there, and now you’re getting careless? Write up that assessment and send it to me within ten minutes.”

“Come on, that’s not it. I’m calling to report something unusual.”

A moment later, the Security Team Leader dropped the roasted egg he was holding.

“He had a USB?”

“Yes. We don’t know who he was talking to, but he said he was keeping the item safe, and he even slipped it out and checked it himself. Junsu saw it with his own eyes, so we’re certain.”

“Th-then what?”

“The target is keeping it on him, apparently… Junsu has no way to do anything about it for now, so I’m reporting it.”

“Junsu—where’s Junsu? Put him on right now.”

“He’s monitoring the target through his Familiar, so that might be difficult.”

The Security Team Leader bit down hard on his lip. His head was a complete mess after hearing the report.

Who was on the other end of that call? Who is the target really? And what the hell is on that USB?

The Security Team Leader’s instincts began to stir.

“Gwondong. This was a special order from the Guild Master. You know that, right? I’ve told you so many times.”

“Everyone knows.”

“If we manage to get even one thing out of this, we all hit the jackpot. I’ll move up, and you’ve put in enough years that you ought to make Team Leader yourself.”

“…It’s not as simple as wishing for it. You know perfectly well they won’t make someone a Team Leader unless they’re at least B-rank.”

“I think this is more than enough to make a real score. I don’t know where that Jin Taekyung bastard crawled out from, but the picture’s obvious. You can tell just by listening to him talk about our Sangdong Guild. Right?”

“I was thinking the same thing.”

The plan was proceeding without a hitch. Sangdong Guild still hadn't noticed anything. And the item was being kept safe.

The conversation between Jin Taekyung and the unidentified person on the other end of the line was meaningful enough even to a third party.

To Sangdong Guild's Security Team, it was unmistakably significant.

"That USB is the key. To put it bluntly, whether it's the Peace Guild Jin Taekyung belongs to or some rival Guild, if they're making a move to bring down our Guild…"

"Then that's seriously high-value intel."

The bonus was a given, and promotion was an option. If he caught the Guild Master's eye, he might even be able to aim for a position among the Guild executives.

At that very moment, the Security Team Leader imagined himself as the Guild Master's right-hand man, while Kim Gwondong became lost in a dream of becoming Sangdong Guild's first C-rank Team Leader.

"Keep watching him. I'll report this up the chain and start by checking Jin Taekyung's call records."

"Yes, sir!"

"I'll change and head over right away. We'll know who the target spoke to by dinner at the latest, so let's work out a plan before then."

The Security Team Leader was about to run to the changing room when Kim Gwondong spoke again.

"Ah, Team Leader. There's one thing I'm worried about…"

"What?"

Anxiety could be heard in Kim Gwondong's voice. And his ominous premonition proved accurate.

"There's Hong Woojin."

"Ah, damn it."

It was a mistake. He had been so excited that he had briefly forgotten about Hong Woojin's existence. The Security Team Leader grew impatient.

It'll be a problem if that bastard moves first.

The Guild Master he knew, Im Chunsoo, was a man who made rewards and punishments absolutely clear.

If a newcomer proved their ability, he would pave the road to advancement for them. But if he decided someone was no good, he would cut them loose without hesitation—even if they had been a Guild member for ten years.

I've seen it more than once or twice.

This wouldn't end with Hong Woojin merely stealing the credit. The Security Team Leader's own position was at stake.

Money? That wasn't the issue. He had devoted half his life to this Guild, and he wanted to see how high he could climb.

"Gwondong."

"Yes."

"That bastard's home alone right now, isn't he?"

"Team Leader, surely not? We can't!"

"I'm not finished."

Unlike Kim Gwondong, whose voice had grown loud, the Security Team Leader remained calm.

"If we subdue the target, take the item, and leave, this ends cleanly. He's only C-rank, after all. There's nothing to be afraid of."

"He's a C-rank who reeks of trouble. If we make the wrong move, we could be the ones who get taken down."

"Taken down? Me, a veteran B-rank, by some rookie who only just awakened as a C-rank? Now that hurts my pride."

"…"

"You don't actually believe what Im Changsoo said, do you? If that were true, it would mean Jin Taekyung was really an A-rank Hunter… If that's the case, you might as well say the Guild Master is a spy. Huh?"

"Come on, why take it that far?"

"Enough. Are you in or not?"

"Fuck, this is driving me crazy."

Kim Gwondong heaved several deep sighs. After a moment, he made his decision.

"If we get caught, we're criminals. You know that, right?"

"I do. I also know we're innocent if we don't get caught."

"Team Leader, you've really got some nerve."

"That's why I'm the Team Leader. What about the others?"

"They're all gathered right now. We mapped out the CCTV coverage on the first day we were deployed, and we have some simple disguise Equipment, too."

"Good."

"When do we start?"

The Security Team Leader licked his dry lips.

"The moment I arrive."

As the old saying went, you had to pull the ox's horn while it was hot. To him, a C-rank Hunter was a soft horn he could yank out one-handed.

It didn't take long for me to realize that the bait had worked.

Meow.

Myaow.

The two Familiars showered me with affection, trying to win me over. But this time was different.

They had struggled up onto the sofa with their short legs, then settled down—not just anywhere, but on my thighs.

They took the bait.

The USB in my pocket was the bait. By now, the watchers must have been dying of curiosity.

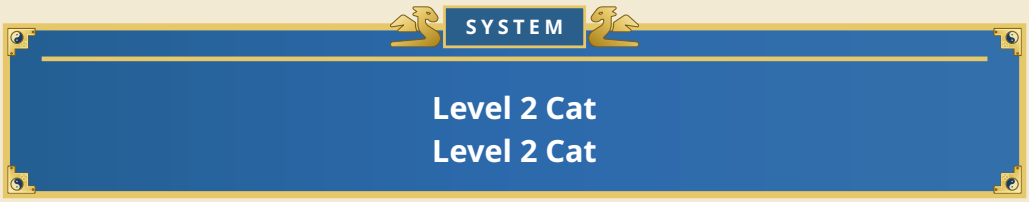
What was the plan I'd mentioned on the phone? Who had I been talking to? And what the hell was on the USB?

I hope they're more daring than I expect.

Neither they nor I stood to gain anything by dragging this out. It was a weekday afternoon, the apartment complex was quiet, and the TV was showing a boring documentary about moving to the countryside to become a farmer.

"Ah, maybe I should visit the hill out back for the first time in a while…"

I muttered to myself and was about to step through the front door when the change I had been waiting for finally came.



The Familiar magic had been dispelled. The meaning was obvious.

They're finally making their move.

In a kitten's body, they couldn't steal the USB from me. But if I, their target, went somewhere secluded on my own, that changed things.

Anyone looking at me would see some middling C-rank Hunter. They'd think they could take it without worry.

Of course, I fully expected a certain amount of violence and intimidation in the process.

But the watchers had gotten one crucial thing wrong.

Me.

They had always been the perpetrators. It had never occurred to them that they might become the victims.

I'm looking forward to this. What kind of bastards are they?

I was going to show them exactly what happened when they stalked someone illegally and without permission.

The information Jin Taekyung had obtained from the real-estate office was only half right. Unlike Sangdong Guild's Security Team, Hong Woojin's hideout was somewhere Taekyung had never expected.

The rooftop of the apartment building where Jin Taekyung lived.

"Whew."

After severing his Link with the Familiar, Hong Woojin opened his eyes inside the tiny supply closet attached to the rooftop.

By slipping the security guard a little money, he had secured the ideal space—roughly five pyeong[639]—for several days.

"This job got horribly tangled up."

Jin Taekyung's suspicious phone call. A USB with unknown contents.

He had finally uncovered something worthy of being called intelligence, but Sangdong Guild had discovered it too.

Hong Woojin stepped out of the supply closet and looked down from the rooftop. Far below, he could see Jin Taekyung just leaving the apartment entrance.

Should I follow him or not?

Considering the job, he should. But something about this felt wrong.

Hong Woojin was watching Jin Taekyung recede into the distance, his eyes conflicted, when—

"Well, look at this."

One person, then another. The way they slowly crawled out was no different from snakes stalking their prey.

Six of them in total.

Each wore different clothes and behaved like an ordinary civilian, but Hong Woojin was in the same line of work. He saw them for what they were.

"Sangdong Guild bastards."

Not one or two, but six of them had come out.

What was more, the target's destination was a deserted hillside. Realizing what was about to happen, Hong Woojin furrowed his brow.

"They're really pulling every dirty trick in the book."

Using force crossed Hong Woojin's line. He should have quit when they deployed the Security Team, despite his repeated warnings when he first accepted the job. But this had gone too far.

I wanted to uncover Jin Taekyung's secrets myself.

He was a man whose identity had made Hong Woojin curious, but this was where it ended. He had a feeling that he shouldn't get involved any further.

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[639] *Pyeong* is a traditional Korean unit of floor area. Five pyeong is about 16.5 m^2, or 178 ft^2.

Sangdong Guild, you goddamn thugs.

Clicking his tongue, Hong Woojin pulled out his smartphone and sent a text.

The recipient was the Team 1 Leader. The message was short and simple.

> **Team 1 Leader**
> I'm dropping the job.

Before leaving the rooftop, he didn't forget to pray for the already-vanished Jin Taekyung's soul.

Well, that was filthy. Let's never see each other again.

In every possible way, the job had brought him nothing but bad luck.

I climbed the mountain path in silence. I had left the hiking trail behind long ago.

But I didn't stop. I kept walking deeper and deeper into the mountain.

At some point, a broad clearing came into view. Weeds had grown thick there, reaching up to my knees. I slowly turned around.

"Looks like you're still out for a walk?"

Kim Gwondong, the middle-aged man I had run into twice before, said nothing. His face hardened.

"No answer? Who's the man beside you?"

"A friend."

If Kim Gwondong had the sort of ordinary face you could see anywhere, the man who answered was his complete opposite.

He was huge, with a vicious face fierce enough to make gangsters cry. A gravelly voice rumbled from between his lips.

"You already know everything, so why did you come all the way here?"

"You kept trailing me from behind, so I wanted to see how far you'd follow. Think of it as training a mutt."

The man burst into a hearty laugh.

"Young punk's got nerve. How old are you?"

"*Yeokmasal*."[640]

"You've got a real talent for asking for a beating."

"Thanks for the compliment, Mr. Choi Byungil."

The man, Choi Byungil, closed his mouth. His eyes wavered.

"…How did you know?"

[640] *Yeokmasal* is a traditional Korean notion of a fate that compels someone to wander. The answer also plays on *sal*, the Korean word used when asking someone's age.

“That’s a trade secret. But are you and Mr. Kim Gwondong really friends? Judging by appearances, you two don’t exactly look like a matching pair.”

This time, it was Kim Gwondong’s turn to panic. But I wasn’t finished.

“Is that hard to answer because you’re not friends? Then I’ll ask the other four. Mr. Park Hyungjin, Mr. Oh Gyuhyeon, Mr. Lee Mincheol, and Mr. Kim Junsu, I’d appreciate an honest answer.”

Bzzzzzz.

The air rippled, and four people dropped straight down.

Each had a Level window floating above his head, and all four looked like they’d seen a ghost.

“Why is everyone so surprised? I was just being considerate so you could breathe easy.”

Choi Byungil gritted his teeth. All traces of his earlier composure had vanished, leaving his face colored by anxiety and bewilderment.

“What the fuck… What kind of bastard are you?”

He had cursed first, so that was the end of respecting my elders. I gave a quiet laugh as I looked at Choi Byungil.

“You still don’t know? You must have dug up every scrap of information about me. If you went so far as to attach Familiars, that says everything.”

“…!”

“I could’ve let it go if I’d been alone at home. But the thought of my family being watched too pissed me off. So I threw out some bait, and you snapped it right up.”

The six watchers trembled.

“Th-then the USB…”

“Oh, that? It’s the porn collection I’ve spent my whole life assembling.”

A treasure of humanity, carefully preserved in my Inventory.

“No way! I definitely had a feeling!”

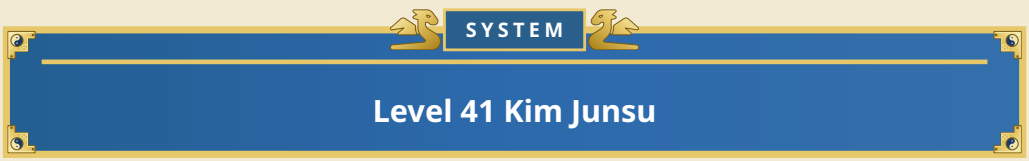
“Well, there are plenty of works in there that defy belief. And any man would get a gut feeling about it.”

I addressed the six of them as they stood there looking utterly crushed.

“You answered honestly, so let me ask you one thing, too.”

One by one, they flinched whenever their eyes met mine.

At last, my gaze settled on a painfully skinny man in his twenties. He was probably the Familiar mage.



“Junsu. Sangdong Guild sent you, didn’t they?”

“Shut your mouth!”

Choi Byungil shouted, but Kim Junsu had already answered.

His bloodless, ashen face was answer enough.

“Okay, Sangdong Guild. I figured as much.”

Choi Byungil’s face stiffened at my words.

“You shouldn’t have said that name out loud.”

“Why? You going to kill me?”

“…I’ll capture you first. Then I’ll think about it.”

“That’s going to be pretty hard.”

Choi Byungil’s Level was in the mid-sixties. His aura was comparable to Im Changsoo’s, while the rest were unremarkable C-ranks around Levels 30 or 40.

The odds of a group that wasn’t even a professional raid team managing to capture me were extremely low.

“Come at me prepared to die. That’s the only way you’ll manage to tie so much as a butterfly knot around my wrist.”

“Get him!”

At Choi Byungil’s shout, the Sangdong Guild watchers began charging at me from all directions.

Whoosh!

The opening move was a dagger dropping toward my shoulder.

I reached toward the trajectory that looked slow to me.

At the same time…

Inventory open. Equip.

Crunch!

The blade, brimming with internal energy, shattered the enemy’s dagger. Shards of metal and someone’s blood spilled across the nameless weeds.

“Come on, you stalker bastards!”

Ssshhhhh!

Chapter 100

Everyone had at least one hobby. Im Chunsoo was no different.

The first thing Team Leader 1 saw when he entered the Guild Master's office was a golf ball rolling toward the door.

Roll, roll. Thunk.

The ball had rolled far wide of the hole and only stopped after striking Team Leader 1's shoe. As he bent down to pick it up, Im Chunsoo waved him off.

"Leave it. Come have some tea."

"Yes, sir."

A brief silence passed between them. After savoring his tea, Im Chunsoo suddenly spoke.

"Smells good, doesn't it?"

"Ah, yes. I suppose it must be good tea."

"This is Longjing tea.[641] I received it as a gift, but to be honest, I don't really know what it is. It's just filthy expensive."

"What?"

"Why are you so surprised?"

"I thought you liked tea."

"Not at all. I only pretend to savor it because I want to look sophisticated. At home, I drink instant coffee."

Team Leader 1 let out a quiet laugh. Im Chunsoo's love of tea was famous among the Guild executives. They had even begun competing to see who could give the Guild Master the better tea.

"A few people are going to be surprised."

"For example?"

"Team Leader 3. He's been bragging that he'll bring back some famous tea from his upcoming business trip to China."

"Fire that bastard. He's lost his mind thinking about gathering weeds instead of doing his job."

"Are you serious?"

"Of course I'm joking. Am I not allowed to joke?"

A light laugh passed between them. Im Chunsoo gulped down the rest of his tea as if it were cold water, then smacked his lips.

"So, when are you going to tell me?"

"Tell you what?"

[641] Longjing, also called Dragon Well, is a Chinese green tea.

“You brought news. I even went out of my way to tell you a secret because you were having trouble spitting it out…”

“Was it that obvious?”

“Look in a mirror before you come in next time. Anyone could tell with a face that grim.”

It wasn’t long before Team Leader 1 finally managed to speak.

“The investigation into the Peace Guild that you ordered previously… has failed.”

“Both of them?”

“Yes. I’m sorry.”

“Explain in more detail.”

“They approached carefully, but they say it would be better not to provoke the Peace Guild Master or Team Leader.”

“I expected as much. I should have made the request personally. In the end, I stayed out of it because of my useless pride, so some of the blame is mine.”

“No, sir. It was my own inadequacy.”

“That’s true, too. Even if those locked-down bastards were out of reach, you should have succeeded with that C-rank Hunter, Jin Taekyung.”

Im Chunsoo shot him a cold glare.

“Why exactly did you fail? I gave you a Familiar mage hired from outside and even assigned the Guild’s Security Team to him.”

“Well, that…”

Team Leader 1 hesitated, then finally forced out the words he had been unable to say.

“We lost contact.”

“Hm? That bastard Hong Woojin?”

“Hong Woojin left a single text message and disappeared. It’s the Security Team we lost contact with.”

“Why the Security Team? Don’t they report in regularly?”

“Yes. Reports come in every two hours, but… the last one was four hours ago.”

“Are you saying the entire Security Team deserted?”

“No. Judging by the circumstances, it’s highly likely Jin Taekyung got to them.”

“What?”

What was that supposed to mean?

As Im Chunsoo stared at him in disbelief, Team Leader 1 handed him a printout.

“Today’s report.”

Only certain sections were printed in red, marking it as an emergency report rather than a routine one.

Im Chunsoo’s eyes raced across the page.

The target had spoken on the phone with an unidentified person, and both the contents of the conversation and the target's actions were suspicious. After reading the report from beginning to end, Im Chunsoo let out a sigh.

"Hah. He's more interesting than I expected. What happened next?"

"The Security Team Leader contacted me directly. He said they needed to pursue the target immediately, so he would act first and report afterward."

"And then they lost contact…"

Deep in thought, Im Chunsoo tapped the table.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

By the time he raised his head, the high-quality wooden table had frozen solid.

"Who did Jin Taekyung call? You must have at least gotten the man's full name, or you wouldn't be showing me this."

"Seong Jinho. A thirty-year-old exam candidate living in Bucheon."

"…Team Leader 1. Did I hear that wrong? An exam candidate, not a Hunter?"

"I checked again myself, but there's no mistake. He's the manager of the goshiwon[642] where Jin Taekyung lives. They're supposedly like sworn brothers."

"Hah. Today keeps surprising me."

Im Chunsoo had expected him to be at least an A-rank Hunter. But what was this? A civilian exam candidate?

Shaking his head, Im Chunsoo rose from his seat.

"Ugh, we really got played. Why does a Guild with only five people have so much to hide?"

"What should we do?"

"What do you mean, what should we do? It's almost dinnertime. We should go have a meal."

"…Sir?"

Im Chunsoo clicked his tongue at the bewildered Team Leader 1.

"Stop talking and follow me."

He was thinking of having dinner in Ilsan that evening.

The six-on-one fight ended in an instant.

To begin with, Choi Byungil was the only one who could exchange blows with me. Even he didn't last long before dropping to his knees.

Well, obviously.

But it seemed to have been a tremendous shock to someone.

[642] A *goshiwon* is a residence of small, inexpensive rooms, originally associated with people studying for competitive exams.

With both ankles broken, Choi Byungil kept talking to me, his face white as a sheet.

“An A-rank Hunter? Were you hiding your identity?”

“No. I never hid my identity.”

“Tell me your real affiliation! Is Ares Guild making a move against our Sangdong Guild…?”

“I’m with the Peace Guild. And Ares Guild probably doesn’t care about your Guild. You’re in completely different weight classes.”

“Then who was the person you called?”

“How many times do I have to tell you? He’s my goshiwon[643] manager hyung.[644] Would you know him if I said his name was Seong Jinho?”

“This can’t be. This can’t be happening.”

In the end, I had no choice but to use the Mouth-Sealing Technique. I tore strips from his clothes and gagged him, then treated all the remaining wounded, including him.

Of course, I didn’t use the potions I had bought from the Store.

“Wow, Sangdong Guild really gives you guys some serious support.”

Even after looting only what they had brought with them, the quality and quantity of their Equipment and consumables were nothing to sneeze at. I used some of them for treatment, and the rest…

“I’m confiscating this for now. Anyone have a problem with that?”

Naturally, no one raised a hand.

They must have been thoroughly cowed by my overwhelming strength. Even after their injuries were treated, none of them dared to attack me again. They were pretty smart.

“Now, who wants to tell me all about your mission?”

Once again, nobody raised a hand, so I had to choose someone myself.

The choice was easy.

“You.”

“M-me?”

“Yeah, you.”

Kim Junsu, the Familiar mage, flinched before declaring with a resolute expression,

“I’m with the Security Team. I cannot carelessly disclose the Guild’s confidential information to an outsider.”

“Oh.”

I was impressed. At the same time, I grabbed him by the hair and yanked.

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[643] A *goshiwon* is a residence of small, inexpensive rooms, originally associated with people studying for competitive exams.

[644] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

A small sound like tape being ripped came from somewhere, and his wig came clean off. The gleaming bald crown hidden beneath it was exposed.

“What the—!”

“From now on, every time you lie or pretend not to know the answer to one of my questions, I’ll pluck out a handful of hair.”

“…!”

Everything went smoothly after that. All kinds of information poured from the mouth of a balding man desperate to protect his hair at any cost.

“Hong Woojin?”

“Yes. He’s a B-rank mage Team Leader 1 hired from outside. Like me, he specializes in Familiar magic.”

“Really?”

What a waste. I should have caught that bastard and beaten the information out of him, too.

I’ll run into him someday. If it takes too long, I can always track him down myself.

Smacking my lips, I continued extracting information. Whenever Kim Junsu seemed to hesitate, I encouraged him by fiddling with what little hair he had left.

“That’s everything. I swear, that’s all. I may be on the Security Team, but I really don’t know anything else. So please, just spare my hair…”

His tone was full of both resentment and sincerity. The final words in particular struck a chord with me.

That should about wrap things up.

The mastermind behind it was, as expected, the Sangdong Guild—or, more precisely, Im Chunsoo.

After seeing that his spendthrift son had been shaken down for a hundred million won[645] in income, he had immediately started digging into our Guild.

Well, in the end, I turned the tables and robbed him instead.

“The Guild Master won’t let this go.”

“Is that some stock line reserved for weaklings? Forget about invoking your Guild Master and worry about cleaning up your own shit.”

“…Tch.”

At my sharp retort, Choi Byungil lowered his head in frustration. Still, he wasn’t entirely wrong.

The Sangdong Guild Master is going to be pretty pissed when he finds out.

He had sent his subordinates to watch me, only for them to get robbed and captured instead. For the Guild Master—and the Guild as a whole—this was about as fucking humiliating as it got.

[645] One hundred million Korean won is about $71,000 or €65,000 at the project rates.

Given the seriousness of the matter, I could only hope they would quietly bury it and move on.

Should I call Team Leader Choi?

I was holding my smartphone, still deliberating, when it happened.

010-xxxx-xxxx

A call from a number I didn't recognize.

What was this?

For some reason, I felt strangely tense as I answered.

"Hello?"

"Come down. I'm waiting below."

"Huh? I think you have the wrong number."

"Jin Taekyung. That's you, isn't it?"

"Well, yes, but… who are you?"

"My name is Im Chunsoo. I heard you have a few of my people with you."

"…"

"Are you listening?"

I was listening. I just couldn't speak.

The Guild Master of a mid-sized Guild had come all the way here himself to meet me. And it was Im Chunsoo, of all people—the man notorious for his temper.

"Come down. We can clear up any misunderstandings over a meal."

There was no misunderstanding to clear up, but I had no idea what would happen if I said, "No."

Hadn't the man already found out my location?

In the end, I had only one option.

"I'll come down now."

Im Chunsoo made a powerful first impression. He was younger than I had expected, and although his eyes seemed gentle, they burned with heat.

Fiery.

Ironically, that was my first thought upon meeting a master of ice magic.

"Hello. I'm Jin Taekyung."

"I'm Im Chunsoo."

Unlike his burning gaze, his voice was cold. At last, he seemed like someone who deserved the nickname Frozen.

"It's strange seeing in person a face I've only seen in report photos."

There were actually people who could admit so bluntly and without embarrassment that they had dug into my background.

“What about my people?”

“They’re upstairs.”

“Any fatalities?”

“Of course not. I’d hate to become a criminal.”

“I appreciate that.”

Im Chunsoo gave me a slight nod.

“My people got impatient and made a mistake. Can you let it slide?”

“If there’s reasonable compensation.”

Im Chunsoo gave a short laugh, while the man beside him, who looked like a Team Leader, frowned.

“Young man, you have no manners.”

“I can be like that… but it feels a little strange hearing it from the people who put me under surveillance.”

“Even so—”

The man couldn’t continue. Im Chunsoo raised a hand to stop him.

“Team Leader 1, go upstairs and release my people.”

“…Yes, Guild Master.”

If Kim Butler possessed a gentle charisma, this man possessed a rough one. Maybe it was because they were both mages. Somehow, the two men overlapped in my mind.

“Come take a walk with me.”

Im Chunsoo went ahead, and I followed behind him.

“Do you know something?”

After walking briskly for a while, Im Chunsoo suddenly spoke.

“Once I have a grudge against someone, I have to see it through to the end. I don’t know about you, but that’s the kind of person I am.”

Very Murim of him.

The strong devour the weak. Survival of the fittest. It seemed this man had the blood of a Murim tough guy running through his veins, too.

“That’s how I built the Sangdong Guild. I climbed higher by stepping on what I had brought down and salvaging whatever I could.”

“I see.”

“What about the Peace Guild?”

“…What do you mean?”

“The past decade has been dull. We’re allies with every nearby Guild, and we haven’t had a rival for a long time. Then you people appeared.”

I looked into his eyes, where curiosity and passion seemed to boil, and had only one thought.

This is dangerous.

Im Chunsoo continued, regardless.

“Your Guild Master and Team Leader are people even I can’t easily access information on… But more than anything, your existence has stirred me up.”

We were climbing a hill now. Despite his considerable age, Im Chunsoo didn’t seem short of breath.

“Do you know why I came all the way here?”

“To see me.”

“You’re only half right.”

Im Chunsoo’s footsteps stopped. Slowly turning around, he released a frigid chill from his entire body.

“At my age, time is money. I’m not so extravagant that I’d come all the way here just to see your face.”

Frozen. The seasoned A-rank mage who had fought his way through the Great Cataclysm himself.

The moment he extended his hand toward me—

Hissssss.

A dozen or so ice spikes formed in the empty air above my head. The midsummer air froze, and frost settled over the scorching dirt path.

I’d been well and truly caught.

I had thought he was an old man with some sense of propriety. I never imagined he would launch straight into something like this.

“Do you really have to go this far?”

“I’m going this far because it’s you.”

“I’m only a C-rank.”

“Exactly. Let’s see what that C-rank Hunter can do.”

The moment he finished speaking, Im Chunsoo clenched his fist. The ice spikes, streaming with biting cold, shot toward me.

Whoosh!

But they couldn’t even touch the hem of my clothes.

“Rise up. Fire Wall.”

At the sound of a clear voice, the mana permeating the air began to churn. The ground, which had been frosted over by Im Chunsoo’s magic, melted as flames surged upward.

Fwoosh! Roar!

It was a wall of fire in the most literal sense. Blue flames swallowed the ice spikes and split the space between Im Chunsoo and me.

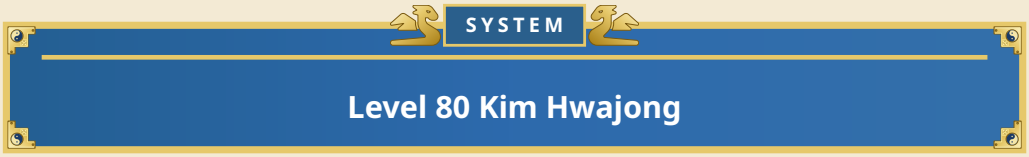
Beyond the wavering flames, Im Chunsoo cried out in shock.

“This is…!”

But I wasn’t looking at Im Chunsoo.

A man standing behind him at the entrance to the hiking trail greeted us in a gentle voice.

“I’m glad I’m not late. You too, Chunsoo.”



Kim Hwajong.

Kim Butler had arrived.

Chapter 101

What the hell is this?

I was dumbfounded. Butler Kim's appearance was unexpected, but that was nothing compared to the words he had directed at Im Chunsoo.

Chunsoo? You?

Did these two know each other?

Come to think of it, Butler Kim and Im Chunsoo had a lot in common. They were around the same age, and both had long careers as Hunters.

Now that I think about it, Butler Kim was active as a Hunter during the Great Cataclysm, too.

I had never heard it directly from him, but I had suspected as much. Looking back and forth between the two men, I carefully asked,

"Are you two close?"

Im Chunsoo's pupils quivered.

When Im Chunsoo first received the report on the Peace Guild, he had doubted his own eyes.

There, in the photograph, was a face from his hazy memories—a face he had been certain he would never see again.

"Wh-who did you say this man was?"

"Peace Guild Master Kim Hwajong. He's fifty-five years old and a B-rank Hunter."

"Kim Hwajong? A B-rank Hunter?"

"Yes. Is something wrong?"

"No, no. He looks like someone I used to know. I mistook him for that person."

That figures.

Im Chunsoo let out a sigh of relief.

The face did resemble him a little, but that was all. More importantly, hadn't that man died over thirty years ago?

No matter how bizarre the world had become, the dead could not come back to life.

Even if that bastard had come back to life, he wouldn't be rotting away in a place like this. I simply mistook him for some washed-up old B-rank Hunter.

That day, Im Chunsoo drank a glass of soju[646] for the first time in a long while and tried to shake off his uneasy feelings. It was an attempt to cast off the terrible memories that had clung to his ankles even after he turned fifty.

[646] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink, commonly made from rice or other starches.

Damn. I'm this old, and I'm still like this.

Later, when he heard that Kim Hwajong's information was protected by airtight security, he had even felt a chill run down his spine.

Could it be? No. There's no way.

But then… why did ominous premonitions never turn out to be wrong?

"Rise up. Fire Wall."

A quiet voice chanting a spell rang out, and a wall of fire surged upward.

Fwoosh! Fwoosh!

Blue flames burning at an extreme temperature vaporized the ice spikes, which were harder than steel, without leaving a trace.

And then—

"I'm glad I'm not too late. You too, Chunsoo."

The moment he heard the voice he could never forget, not even in his dreams, Im Chunsoo remembered.

The terror of being under that man's thumb.

The humiliation of rolling around on the ground just to survive.

Fuck… I'm screwed.

As he stood frozen like a stone, Jin Taekyung asked him,

"Are you two close?"

What? Close?

Im Chunsoo swallowed the torrent of curses rising from deep in his lungs and turned around.

There stood the man he had believed long dead.

"I-Instructor."

Butler Kim smiled gently. It was the smile of a demon still deeply engraved in Im Chunsoo's mind, even after all these years.

"Twenty-eighth Regiment, First Battalion, Second Company. Im Chunsoo. Yes, I recognized you the moment I saw you."

The words resonated in his very soul.

Im Chunsoo's hunched back straightened. His heels came together at a forty-five-degree angle, and his gaze turned fifteen degrees upward toward the front.

After a series of movements as fast as lightning, a thunderous shout burst out.

"Trainee Number One! Im! Chun! Soo!"

The mountain shook as he bellowed out his military identification for the first time in thirty years.

When Team Leader 1 reached the top of the mountain, he found grass splattered with blood in several places and the Security Team trussed up in magical ropes.

What a disgraceful sight.

Clicking his tongue inwardly, he drew his sword and cut them loose.

They had all shed some blood, but none of them appeared seriously injured. Jin Taekyung seemed to have shown them at least the bare minimum of consideration.

At this level, he's either a top-tier B-rank… or an A-rank Hunter.

That was Team Leader 1's assessment of Jin Taekyung's strength.

For one man, the walk back down the mountain was sheer hell.

"Why did you do it? We might have been able to smooth over the surveillance, but what happened today could amount to attempted murder. Did you even consider the consequences before resorting to violence?"

"…I'm sorry."

At Team Leader 1's words, the Security Team Leader hung his head.

He had gone so far as to make a reckless show of force, only to have Jin Taekyung wipe the floor with them. Even if he had ten mouths, he would have had nothing to say.

"The Guild Master is deeply disappointed."

"Th-then?"

"A written apology and a pay cut are a given. Be prepared for worse."

"Are you talking about resignation?"

"That's up to the Guild Master."

"Team Leader, perhaps…"

"Let me tell you up front: don't ask me for any favors. I don't have any interest in taking the side of someone who smeared the name of the company I work for. And I have no intention of going against the Guild Master's wishes."

"…"

"Whew."

Team Leader 1 let out an irritated sigh.

That was when a booming shout echoed from far away.

—Trainee Number One! Im! Chun! Soo!

"…"

"…"

What was that? Were they hearing things?

Team Leader 1 and even the Security Team members, who had all looked ready to die, jumped in surprise. The first to recover his composure was the Security Team Leader.

“Team Leader 1, I’m sorry to bring this up in this kind of atmosphere, but I think I just heard the Guild Master’s voice.”

Team Leader 1, who had been cleaning out his ears, opened his eyes wide.

“…You heard it too?”

“We heard it, too.”

“We couldn’t tell whether it was the Guild Master’s voice, though… I think we heard his name.”

“That was a person’s name? I thought it was just someone screaming.”

“Really? I thought it sounded like someone giving their name and rank.”

Team Leader 1’s face hardened as he listened to the Security Team whispering among themselves.

“Who just said that? What was that about giving a name and rank?”

To him, Im Chunsoo was a respected Senior as well as his superior.

He was a peerless Hunter who had been active since the Great Cataclysm—a war hero. And they were saying he had suddenly reported his military identification?

Team Leader 1 had never imagined such a thing. He *couldn’t* imagine it.

“Do you still have the leisure to spout this kind of nonsense? Do you think this is something people in their right minds would say?”

“S-sorry.”

“We must have misheard.”

“Get a grip, all of you. Understood?”

Team Leader 1 had just resumed walking after delivering the warning when it happened again.

—No, sirrrrr!

“…”

—I’ll correct it, sirrrr!

“…”

It was the soul-deep roar of a private second class.

A moment later, Team Leader 1’s tightly sealed mouth finally opened.

“From this moment on, we run at full speed. Move!”

“M-Move!”

Everyone gathered there was at least a C-rank Hunter. They were superhuman beings who had already far surpassed the limits of ordinary people.

They thundered downhill like runaway locomotives and reached the hiking-trail entrance in under five minutes.

“Slow as hell. You’re only getting here now?”

“Guild Master!”

“Keep it down. You’ll burst my eardrums.”

Team Leader 1 sighed in relief when he saw Im Chunsoo looking the same as ever.

“I thought something might have happened…”

“Something? Was there anything strange?”

“N-no, sir. But where did that Jin Taekyung bastard go?”

“I gave him a talking-to and sent him on his way. After speaking with him, I found out he was a better fellow than I expected. Why?”

“I thought he might have caused some kind of disturbance.”

“Oh, you mean the guy who was shouting earlier?”

“Yes, that’s right. But the voice sounded exactly…”

He couldn’t bring himself to finish.

Exactly like yours, Guild Master.

Im Chunsoo glared at him.

“Exactly like what?”

“Oh, it was nothing.”

“How bland. Some greenhorns were playing army down there, so I chased them away. Do colleges still have hazing culture these days?”

“Ah, I see.”

“What was it? I made them do some PT exercises for a while, and they looked ready to die.”

Team Leader 1 felt all his lingering suspicions disappear.

I must have been out of my mind. How dare I even think such a thing?

While he reflected deeply on his mistake, Im Chunsoo laid into the Security Team.

“Security Team Leader.”

“Y-yes, sir!”

“Well, look at that. You certainly know how to answer. After causing this mess, are you still a Team Leader just because you’re technically still a Team Leader?”

“I’m sorry!”

“Are the others keeping their mouths shut because they did such a good job? Do you want me to make my sword dance today?”

“We’re sorry, Guild Master!”

Team Leader 1 watched the scene with a pleased smile.

Every so often, there were people who spread the rumor that Im Chunsoo had a godawful personality. But after watching him up close, Team Leader 1 knew better. He was a charismatic superior and an outstanding Senior in life.

Guild Master. I’ll follow you forever.

As he gazed at Im Chunsoo’s back with boundless respect, Team Leader 1 suddenly cocked his head.

…But why is there dirt on the Guild Master’s back?

He must have scolded those kids rather intensely.

“We’ve arrived.”

At Butler Kim’s words, sitting in the passenger seat, I came to my senses with a start and looked around. Through the window, I could see the entrance to an apartment complex.

When did we get here?

“Th-thank you.”

“Don’t mention it.”

A smile appeared on his handsomely lined face. He looked like a middle-aged actor who had once ruled an era.

No, this man really did rule an era, too.

Until now, I had thought of him as nothing more than a Senior Hunter from a distant generation. But that meant I hadn’t understood Butler Kim at all.

He worked an A-rank mage like a dog—and Im Chunsoo, no less.

He had made a former war hero do a hundred sets of PT Exercise No. 8[647], then later kicked him in the shin with his dress shoe. Even now, the way he had calmly berated Im Chunsoo in that gentle voice sent chills down my spine.

“Trainee, who uses mana during PT exercises?”

Whack!

“Trainee Number One Im Chunsoo. S-sorry, sir.”

“Does it hurt? Now that you’ve gotten older, has your voice gotten quieter, too?”

“No, sirrrrr!”

“Attention. At ease. Attention. At ease.”

Snap-snap-snap-snap!

“On your backs. On your fronts. On your backs. On your backs.”

Gasp.

“Trainee, didn’t you hear this Instructor say on your backs? Get your head straight.”

“I’ll correct it, sirrrr!”

“And why are you bullying an innocent junior? Hasn’t this Instructor told you time and again that Seniors and juniors should help each other?”

“S-sorry, sir.”

“Repeat after me. Cherish your junior on the way down. Cherish your junior on the way up. One. Two.”

“Cherish my junior!”

[647] PT Exercise No. 8 is a numbered physical-training drill in Korean military-style calisthenics.

"Trainee, I remember you're Class 25. Am I right?"

"Trainee Number One Im Chunsoo. Yes, sir."

"This Instructor is Class 3. If what happened today gets out or happens again, Classes 4 through 24 will assemble without exception."

"…"

"Why aren't you answering? Prepare for squat jumps."

"P-prepare, sir…"

He worked him over, and over, and over again.

It was the kind of sight you couldn't see even if you paid for it. If the Sangdong Guild members had witnessed it, the Guild might have had to close its doors that very day.

Who the hell is Butler Kim, really?

Being Class 3 at the Hunter Training Center meant he could line up every Guild Master in the country on a parade ground and beat every last one of them with a bat.

And he had been an Instructor, no less.

It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that nearly every mage from the early days of the Great Cataclysm had passed through his hands.

He's at least A-rank as a mage, too.

I could tell just by watching Im Chunsoo take his punishment without daring to make a peep. Butler Kim surpassed him in both seniority and skill.

There was probably also an elemental advantage between ice and fire. You could say Butler Kim was the one who taught Im Chunsoo and raised him to his current position.

But…

Why was someone that accomplished working as a butler?

I stole a sidelong glance at Butler Kim, only for our eyes to meet.

"You seem to have a lot you want to ask."

"To be honest, I do."

My curiosity was killing me.

Seeing my thoughts written plainly across my face, Butler Kim curled up the corners of his mouth.

"It's a long story."

"That's fine. I'm on vacation, so I have plenty of time."

"Ah, then this is a good opportunity to hear your story as well, Mr. Jin. I already have more than one or two questions myself."

"Now that I think about it, it's already dinnertime. Tomorrow is the last day of my vacation, so I have to sign a real-estate contract, too. Hahaha."

"…"

Chapter 102

Everyone has their own area of expertise.

I knew Gate formations, how to respond in a crisis, and the weaknesses of various monsters like the back of my hand. By the same token, I knew next to nothing about legal matters.

“Thank you for your hard work.”

“You too.”

The man in the angular horn-rimmed glasses was the judicial scrivener[648] I had hired to handle the purchase of the house. Across from me, the homeowner and the realtor were exchanging farewells and getting to their feet.

“Congratulations on the contract. You’ve done well for yourself at such a young age.”

“Ah, yes. Thank you.”

As I shook hands with the homeowner, something finally sank in.

This is my house now.

And it was my family’s house.

A home we had reclaimed after no less than eleven years.

I looked around the cramped room.

The bed whose springs had given out long ago. A small wardrobe that could barely hold a few outfits. A desk with paint peeling off in places, with a small TV sitting on top.

Once I packed my clothes and assorted belongings, aside from the things I had to leave behind, they filled a single cardboard box.

Just one box.

The past seven years were contained inside it. I was staring around the room, my chest strangely tight, when a voice came from behind me.

“You leaving?”

I knew who it was without turning around.

He was someone I couldn’t leave out of my seven years.

“Yeah.”

“What about the house?”

“I found one, so I’m moving out.”

“Bastard, that was fast. Has your family already moved into the new place?”

[648] In South Korea, a judicial scrivener handles legal and registration work for matters such as real-estate transactions.

"No. It's still a secret. I'm planning to move in first and tell them after my sister finishes her college entrance exam."

"Fair enough. She's at an important stage."

"Yeah. I need to remodel the place first, too."

A brief silence followed. We were comfortable enough not to need conversation, the kind of people who could read each other's thoughts from a look alone. But right now, neither of us seemed to know what to say.

"Hyung[649]."

"Hey, hey. That's enough. Don't make this all sentimental."

Jinho hyung[650] slapped me hard on the back.

"You're not some elementary school kid transferring schools. Just because you're moving, you're not going to stop seeing me, are you?"

"Of course I'll see you. I definitely will."

"Then it's fine. Besides, I'm moving my stuff out by the end of today, too."

"You are?"

"I told you last time. Don't you remember?"

"Oh, right. You did."

I had felt bad about leaving Jinho hyung[651] alone in the goshiwon[652] after all the years we had spent living together. Now I finally felt a little more at ease.

"Where are you moving?"

"Well, I ended up crashing at someone I know's place. Where did you say the house you bought was?"

"Goyang. It's only thirty minutes from here, so it's not that far."

"Goyang?"

Jinho hyung's[653] eyes widened.

"I'm in that area too, you punk!"

"Huh? Really?"

The unexpected news secretly pleased me. By now, I missed his face if I went even a day without seeing it. If we lived close by, we could still meet often.

"Hyung[654], then what's the exact address—"

Just as I was about to ask, the smartphone in my pocket rang. When I answered, a gravelly voice came through the receiver.

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[649] *Hyung* is a term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

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"Hello, is this Mr. Jin Taekyung? I'm in front of the goshiwon[655] right now."

"Ah, yes. Driver."

It was the private moving-truck driver I had called in advance. I glanced out the window and saw a blue light truck waiting in front of the goshiwon[656].

"Do you have a lot of stuff? If anything's heavy, I can help you carry it."

"No, it's fine. I'll carry it myself."

I only had two things to move.

A cardboard box filled with small belongings, and…

The capsule.

Now that the Logout function had been activated, I no longer needed the capsule to travel between Murim and the modern world.

It had become nothing more than a bulky nuisance, but it meant more to me than anything else. It was the only reason I had called a moving truck despite having so little luggage.

What would have happened if it weren't for this capsule?

I slowly ran my hand over its surface. The coldness of the metal and its rough texture traveled through my fingers.

This one old capsule had completely changed my life.

Oh, right. Someone else played a big part in that too.

"Jinho hyung[657]."

"Yeah?"

A laugh escaped me at his puzzled expression.

If Jinho hyung[658] hadn't gotten plastered that day, I never would have entered the capsule in the first place.

"Never mind. It's nothing."

"You're no fun. Anyway, shouldn't you get going? There's a truck waiting outside."

"Yeah. Since you're here, carry that box down for me. I have to carry the capsule, so I don't have a free hand."

"Uh, what?"

"What's with that reaction? Can't you carry one box for your little brother who's moving away?"

"That's not it… Ah, now that I think about it, I need to pack my own stuff too. Even if it's a hassle, just make one trip back and forth. Well, good luck!"

"…"

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[657] *Hyung* is a term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[658] *Hyung* is a term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

Look at him slithering away like a loach.

I watched Jinho hyung's[659] back inch into the distance, then finally picked up the box myself.

The moving driver, tired of waiting, honked the truck's horn. The sound struck my ears.

Honk, honk!

"Yes, I'm coming down!"

"Are you a Hunter?"

The moving driver, who had been sneaking glances at me, finally spoke. With the box and capsule loaded in the back, the truck followed the navigation toward my new home.

"How did you know?"

"You can tell at a glance. I used to be a Hunter, too. F-rank."

"Oh, really?"

"I'm probably your Senior by training-center class. Ah, I'm not trying to pull rank. It'd be ridiculous for a guy who quit after exactly one month and handed back his license to act like some old-timer."

The driver continued as though airing a long-held grievance.

"Being a Hunter at the training center was manageable. Even though I was only F-rank, I took pride in becoming a Hunter. But the moment I joined a Guild after graduating, an accident happened."

An accident at a Gate was synonymous with death.

Even if someone lost an arm or a leg, they could recover as long as they had enough money. Hunters didn't call something like that an accident.

"He was one of my training-center classmates, and he joined the Guild at the same time as me… Before I knew what was happening, he was dragged away and died just like that. I should have chased after him and saved him, no matter what it took, but I couldn't make my feet move. After his funeral, I applied for retirement. Someone like me had no business going on raids."

He tried to sound calm, but he couldn't hide the slight tremor in his voice.

"Listen to me saying something so ominous in front of a Hunter customer. It's not even a pleasant story. Sorry about that."

"Don't worry about it."

I understood how he felt.

[659] *Hyung* is a term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

I had experienced something similar. If I hadn't felt responsible for my family, and if Jinho hyung[660] hadn't been there to comfort me, I might have retired two years ago.

Then my life would have turned out completely differently.

Being a Hunter was a brutal profession. The media praised them as humanity's guardians and shields, but they lived with death always at their side.

"Turn right in fifty meters[661]."

The driver paused at the navigation's voice, then muttered, "Oh, come to think of it, this is a safe zone."

"That's right. Just keep going."

"Ah, yes."

The truck arrived at its destination soon afterward.

A two-story detached house with a blue roof. A low stone wall and a yard covered in grass. It felt different from when I had first seen it a few days ago.

It must be because it's ours now.

Our house.

The more I repeated those words in my head, the better they sounded. Of course, the fact that the house itself was beautiful probably helped.

"Wow… It's a nice house."

The driver climbed out of the cab and clicked his tongue in admiration. Praise always sounded sweeter coming from someone else. No matter how hard I tried to suppress it, the corners of my mouth kept rising.

"You must be a successful Hunter. Living in a house like this was my dream."

"Mine too."

"Your wish came true. You must be happy."

Of course. I was ecstatic.

The driver continued exclaiming over the place, touching the stone wall and looking over the lawn, before asking,

"Would it be all right if I took a quick look inside? I can help move the capsule while I'm at it."

"Sure. Go ahead."

The moving driver became the new house's first guest by accident as he climbed into the truck bed to move the capsule.

"That thing must weigh quite a bit."

"It's fine. I've moved plenty of them, so I know. Game capsules all weigh about the same."

"No, it's seriously heavy."

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[660] *Hyung* is a term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[661] Fifty meters is about 164 ft.

I knew because I had lifted it myself earlier. It had felt reasonably hefty even to me, with my Strength stat in the triple digits. For the driver, it would be a different story entirely.

“Boss, I’ll move it myself.”

The driver wrapped his arms around the capsule and grinned.

“Come on. You’re underestimating me. I was a Hunter back in the day. Something like this is—nnngh!”

“Oh, wow.”

As expected of a former Hunter, he did manage to lift it in one go.

The only change was that the smile had vanished from his face.

“Go ahead and open the doors. Quickly!”

At the urgency in his voice, I dashed ahead and threw open the front gate and the front door. I had no idea why I was getting nervous too.

“I can carry it—”

“Move!”

“Ah, yes.”

He barreled into the living room at a speed fit for an alarm and screamed, “Which room?!”

“I was going to put the capsule upstairs…”

“What?!”

“…but just leave it in the nearest room.”

Fortunately, the door to one of the rooms was already open. The driver set the capsule down with a thud and began panting.

“Why… is this… huff… so heavy?”

“…”

Hadn’t I told him it was heavy?

As soon as the moving driver left, I dropped onto the living room sofa.

It was one of the pieces of furniture the previous owner had transferred to me on the condition that I pay the remaining balance all at once.

I’ll have to live alone for a few months.

I had told my family that I was going back to Bucheon.

Until Hayeon finished her college entrance exam, I planned to eat and sleep here while commuting to work.

I need to remodel the house and buy a car too. Ah, the Guild said they’d provide me with a car anyway, so I need to get my license first.

There was a mountain of other things to do. But instead of feeling tired, I felt energized. These were all things I hadn't been able to do before, no matter how much I wanted to.

It had only been a few months since I had done nothing but suffer while going back and forth between Gates and the goshiwon[662], yet so much had changed.

You've come a long way, Jin Taekyung.

One person suddenly came to mind.

A man who had always smiled like a boy despite his age. A man who had done his best for his wife and children and approached them like a friend.

Dad, I bought a house. The place we used to live in was already gone. But I did well enough, right?

I wanted to brag about it like a child, but the person who would have praised me had passed away long ago. All I could do was repeat words in my heart that would never reach him.

How much time passed like that?

When I came to my senses, it was already eight in the evening. The summer sun was slowly setting.

So this is how my last day of vacation ends.

An entire week of vacation. It had been hectic because of everything involving the Sangdong Guild, but it was still the best rest I had enjoyed since becoming a Hunter.

Now it was time to return to my daily life.

In exactly twelve hours.

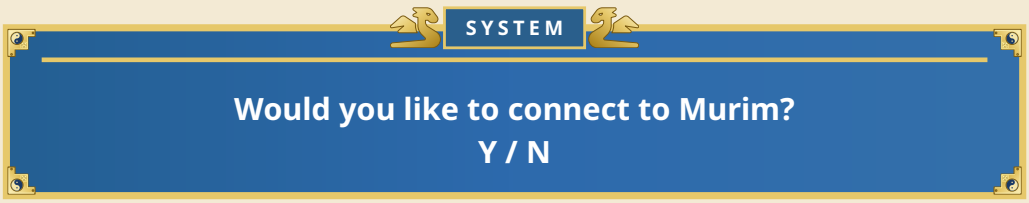
I lay flat on the sofa where I had been sitting. I briefly considered entering the capsule, but soon dismissed the thought.

After eleven years, I finally had a home again. Just this once, I wanted to wake up in our living room instead of inside that stuffy capsule.

Login.

The System responded to my call.

Ding.



Of course, my answer was yes.

[662] A *goshiwon* is a building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, originally intended for students preparing for exams.

Long after Jin Taekyung lost consciousness, something no one could have expected was happening in the room beside the front door.

Hissssss.

The door of the metal object that looked like a gigantic egg—the capsule—slowly began to open.

The first thing to emerge was a pair of feet.

Red letters were printed across a pair of long athletic socks that reached up to the calves.

Hope Goshiwon[663] Early-Morning Soccer Club

Next came sweatpants rolled up halfway, followed by a pair of pale, skinny hands. The cover of the book he clutched tightly, as though it were scripture, gleamed in the sunset pouring through the window.

Complete Mastery of the Civil Service Exam

And finally, his face emerged.

After enduring several long hours of agony, he looked as haggard as Crown Prince Sado[664] yet as relieved as Park Hyeokgeose[665] emerging from an egg.

A parched voice slipped between his bone-dry lips.

“Is this my new nest…?”

As Seong Jinho gazed around the spacious room, a satisfied smile spread across his lips.

[663] A *goshiwon* is a building of small, inexpensive rented rooms, originally intended for students preparing for exams.

[664] Crown Prince Sado was an eighteenth-century Joseon royal who died after being confined in a wooden rice chest.

[665] Park Hyeokgeose is the legendary founder of the ancient Korean kingdom of Silla, said to have been born from an egg.

Chapter 103

Clatter, clatter.

The carriage lurched dangerously under the hands of an inexperienced coachman.

Though it was a fairly well-maintained makeshift road, several days of heavy snow had frozen the whip into an icicle that kept jabbing the horses in the rump.

And then, at last, trouble struck.

Thud!

Neigh!

The four fine horses, which had been moving their hooves quite quickly despite the slippery snow, suddenly stopped.

“Gah!”

The coachman nearly pitched forward but somehow managed to regain his balance. Yet more than the relief of avoiding a fall, he was consumed by fear of what was about to happen.

Please, Jade Emperor, Primordial Heavenly Venerable.[666]

Had his desperate prayer been answered? He cautiously peeked inside the carriage, but the two young men sat there as though nothing had happened.

Well, technically, one of them is asleep.

One young man was buried in fur until only his forehead peeked out. Perhaps someone had pressed a sleep-inducing pressure point, because he showed no sign of waking. The other sat cross-legged, utterly absorbed in circulating his qi.

Sssssip. Hooooo.

If anyone had witnessed the scene, they would have been surprised twice.

Once by the young man’s handsome features, and once again by the formless qi of a Peak master pouring from his body.

Even Hyuk Mujin, the coachman, who thought he had grown somewhat accustomed to him by now, was no exception.

What kind of bullshit is this?

His envy had gone beyond envy and reached the point of anger.

A handsome face and genius-level martial talent. If he possessed even one of those, he would have no other wish in the world. But that young man, Jin Mukyung, had both.

And there’s even another one.

The same went for the other young man, Jin Taekyung, who had said he would circulate his qi only to fall asleep like the dead.

No, he might be an even greater monster than his older brother, Jin Mukyung.

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[666] The Jade Emperor and Primordial Heavenly Venerable are major figures in Daoist cosmology.

After all, only a few months ago, he had been a Third Rate wastrel who did nothing but visit pleasure houses. Now he was the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

How can two brothers be this alike?

They had fully inherited the looks of their mother, once known as Shanxi's foremost beauty. Their talent was extraordinary enough to inspire jealousy.

And lastly…

They're both assholes.

Hyuk Mujin glared at the brothers in turn.

One had taken all the fur for himself to keep warm, without caring whether his subordinate froze to death on the driver's bench. The other had given him hell for a full shichen[667] because he couldn't drive a carriage properly, and now he was comfortably circulating his qi.

They really are perfectly matched.

That phrase was supposed to describe brothers whose excellence made them impossible to rank, but these two were the exact opposite.

Hyuk Mujin was carefully considering which brother had the worse personality when it happened.

"Hey."

A chilly voice. Irresistible formless qi poured from the eyes of the man who had just finished circulating his qi, binding Hyuk Mujin in place.

"What are you doing? Why aren't you driving?"

"Well, a problem came up for a moment."

"What problem?"

"Well…"

What would happen if he said the horses were angry because the frozen whip kept stabbing them in the rump? Hyuk Mujin made the wise choice.

"My body is frozen, so I can't drive."

He also wanted a break. Didn't the backside that had been suffering on the driver's bench deserve some rest?

But Jin Mukyung's response was simple.

"Hand."

"Pardon?"

"Give me your hand."

Hyuk Mujin reflexively held out his hand like a mutt. Jin Mukyung grabbed it and casually said,

"Bear with the heat."

[667] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

Before Hyuk Mujin could understand what he meant, an enormous surge of qi rushed through his fingertips. The fire qi was so intense that his entire body seemed to catch fire, and his breath caught in his throat.

Gah!

The shock was too great for a scream to come out. It lasted no more than an instant, but Hyuk Mujin stood there with his mouth hanging open, his body trembling violently. He did not even realize that Jin Mukyung had already let go of his hand.

"How is it? Better?"

Only then did Hyuk Mujin come to his senses. He barely managed to open his mouth.

"W-what was that just now?"

"A simple type of heat-yang technique."

"That didn't look simple… I thought I was going to burn to death."

"Really? I suppose I'm still unskilled since I only learned it superficially."

Jin Mukyung's offhand tone left Hyuk Mujin dumbfounded.

Why would you use something you only learned superficially on me…?

Perfectly matched? When it came to being an asshole, the older brother won by a mile.

Jin Taekyung had beaten him up before, but he had never tried to burn him to death with a heat-yang technique.

"Now that you've thawed out, go drive the carriage. We still have a long way to go."

"…"

He hadn't been thawed out so much as roasted, but the effect was undeniable.

"Then I'll get us moving again."

When Hyuk Mujin returned to the driver's bench, his body radiating heat, Jin Mukyung turned his gaze forward.

Jin Taekyung was buried so thoroughly in fur that it was difficult to tell whether he was a bear or a person.

He said he was going to circulate his qi, but he's sprawled out asleep.

Mukyung had thought he was talking nonsense, but he hadn't expected him to sleep so brazenly. A martial artist was supposed to constantly ponder martial arts and train without rest.

Jin Mukyung roared with a stern expression.

"You rascal! Will you not get up this instant?"

His voice boomed so loudly that Hyuk Mujin on the driver's bench and even the horses flinched. Yet Jin Taekyung himself did not stir.

Snnn. Snnn.

"You rascal!"

Jin Mukyung sprang to his feet and struck his younger brother's forehead with his palm. With a sharp smack, the skin turned bright red.

Let's see if this wakes you up.

Smack, smack, smack.

Snnn. Snnn.

"…"

His forehead had gone beyond red. A lump had risen and looked ready to burst, yet he didn't so much as twitch.

Jin Mukyung was overwhelmed by shock. Even a commoner without a shred of internal energy should have screamed awake from this. Yet this guy, supposedly a Supreme First Rate martial artist and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, did not move an inch.

Jin Mukyung had never seen anyone so defenseless in all his life.

And that guy is my younger brother.

Just as the training he had put Taekyung through over the past several days was beginning to feel like a complete waste of time—

"Hmm."

The eyes that had seemed destined to remain closed forever slowly opened.

Before I even opened my eyes, I realized that I had returned to Murim.

The cool air against my cheek. The rattling interior of the carriage.

And pain.

"…?"

Wait. Why was I in pain?

When I opened my eyes, a fairly familiar face was looking down at me.

Jin Mukyung.

I ignored the look on his face, which seemed to say *What kind of guy is this?*, and straightened my slumped body. Only then did I identify the source of the pain.

"Ow."

My forehead. When I carefully touched it, I felt a lump and the heat radiating from the surrounding skin.

What the hell is this?

What could I possibly have done here to get a lump on my forehead?

For a moment, I wondered if I had slammed my head against the wall. But with the bones, muscles, and toughness I had steadily built up, that wouldn't even leave a scratch.

Someone hit me on purpose. No question.

As it happened, there were two suspects right in front of me.

Jin Mukyung and Hyuk Mujin. Even a three-year-old could tell who the culprit was.

“What did you do while I was asleep?”

“While you were sleeping? Didn’t you say you were circulating your qi before that?”

“…I did?”

It had been so long that I couldn’t even remember. But that wasn’t important right now.

“You hit someone while they were sleeping?”

“You looked so pathetic that I did. A martial artist like you sprawled out asleep instead of training.”

“You call yourself a martial artist, yet you underhandedly attack a defenseless opponent?”

“Then shall we get off right now and have a bout? Like true martial artists?”

We both sprang to our feet and glared at each other without waiting for the other to move first. Jin Mukyung spoke in an ominous tone.

“Hyung Mujin.”

“It’s Hyuk Mujin. Second Young Master, please.”

“Stop the carriage.”

“…Yes, sir.”

The carriage slowly began to decelerate. Now it was my turn. I met his gaze and spoke.

“Hyuk Mujin.”

“Ah, why me this time, Captain?”

“Keep going.”

“Haah, this is driving me crazy.”

The carriage began to speed up again. As I slowly sat back down, Jin Mukyung asked incredulously,

“Didn’t I suggest that we have a bout like martial artists?”

“How pathetic. The mission comes first, and fighting comes after. And…”

“And?”

“I never said we should fight. I only said you were underhanded.”

“…”

I said it as confidently as possible, but there was no hiding how lame it looked.

I snuck a look at Jin Mukyung’s Level window.

SYSTEM

Lv. ??? Jin Mukyung

Right. Come on, fighting him the moment I got back would be a bit much.

Check the Quest window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest

Yesterday's Enemy, Today's Ally

Now that all the truth has been revealed, the Mount Heng Sword Sect is no longer an enemy but an ally you must join forces with. Invite them to the Jin Family of Taiyuan for the upcoming New Year's Day.

Grade: First Rate

Restriction: Jin Taekyung

Mission: Deliver the invitation (Incomplete)

Reward: ???

Failure: None

I took another look at the last Quest I had received.

It was an easy mission. The Quest's Grade wasn't particularly high, and there was no penalty for failure. All I had to do was deliver the invitation to the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect…

The current Mount Heng Sword Sect had been reduced to its bare bones. Once Lee Seogeun was poisoned and the pillar known as Lee Cheonbaek fell, its collapse had been swift.

The battle at Eight Spring Gorge was the fatal blow.

They say words without feet can travel a thousand li.[668]

That day's battle, watched by countless eyes and ears, spread rapidly through messenger pigeons and word of mouth. With nearly all its main forces gone, the Mount Heng Sword Sect became easy prey for someone.

Wandering martial artists. And mounted bandits.

They said as many as two hundred attackers had suddenly raided the Mount Heng Sword Sect. After two days and nights of fighting, the attackers were driven off.

[668] A Chinese li is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

Lee Seogwang, who had remained at the sect after being placed under disciplinary confinement, ultimately fell in battle.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect needed a new rallying point, and one person emerged.

Lee Seowol.

Lee Cheonbaek's last surviving descendant and the current Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

We had to deliver this invitation to her.

The problem was…

Things between us were seriously awkward.

Actually, "awkward" was putting it mildly, at least from my perspective.

In a way, the two of us had been at the starting point of all this.

I think it was right after I came out of the training hall.

I remembered Wipeng's words exactly, down to the last syllable.

"Is it true that you tried to force yourself on the daughter of the Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

These days, everyone knew I was innocent. But back then, I had been treated like the worst bastard under heaven.

Lee Seogeun, who had come to pressure the Jin Family of Taiyuan with fabricated evidence, was poisoned on his way home, and that was the beginning of everything.

It's only been a month or two.

The Third Rate wastrel despised by his own family had become the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, while the woman whose name I hadn't even known was now the new Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

We had both gone through so many changes in that time that, in a sense, we had something in common.

Our positions are very different, though.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was now, by everyone's admission, the foremost family in Shanxi.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect, on the other hand, was nothing more than an empty shell. In truth, this invitation was practically an offer to surrender and come under the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I would have to experience it firsthand to know how Lee Seowol would react.

I just hope she doesn't suddenly stab me.

Just as I closed the Quest window, sunlight streamed in and the sound of a boisterous crowd drew closer. Hyuk Mujin looked at me, his face flushed with excitement.

"We're at Honju."

The distance between her and me had narrowed to two days.

Chapter 104

A city that never sleeps.

That was my first impression of Honju. Even though it was a dark night, the streets lined with countless pavilions were bright with lanterns, and the sound of people laughing and talking never stopped.

More than I expected.

It wasn't quite as lively as a modern city at night, but it was still a well-developed commercial district.

How should I put it? Maybe the culture of this era had a unique charm all its own.

Oh, that looks pretty cool.

Unlike me, who was gazing out the window with interest, Jin Mukyung looked unimpressed.

"It's noisy. We'd be better off camping outdoors."

"Come on, we're only passing through. Why complain?"

Hyuk Mujin's cheeky reply made Jin Mukyung's eyebrow twitch.

"If you'd driven the carriage properly, we would have passed through long ago."

"If the Second Young Master hadn't chased away the coachman in the first place…"

"What?"

"Nothing. I'm the one who deserves to die."

Wincing at the sharp glare, Hyuk Mujin began rambling excuses.

"Still, we're representing the family. Shouldn't we eat something good at a good place? And let the horses rest, too."

"Food need only stave off hunger. Besides, who told you to do any of that?"

"The Lesser Family Head."

"…Brother did?"

"Yes. He repeatedly told me that since we were traveling without any attendants, we should at least take care of our meals and lodging somewhere decent."

I should've been that bastard's older brother.

Jin Mukyung had a terrible personality and never listened to anyone, but he was completely helpless in front of his only older brother. After hesitating for a moment, he sighed.

"Fine. Just hurry up and go."

"Yes, sir."

Hyuk Mujin had finally won one battle. With the corner of his mouth twitching, he began driving the carriage.

The carriage stopped in front of a massive four-story wooden building.

The Phoenix Inn. Its signboard, written in elegant calligraphy, was striking.

“This place looks incredibly expensive.”

“Of course it is. This is where the Young Masters of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan will be staying. The Lesser Family Head told me repeatedly—we have to choose the absolute best!”

“…”

He’s awfully excited when it’s someone else’s money.

I shook my head and climbed down from the carriage. An inn boy who looked about middle-school age scurried over and bowed at the waist.

“Welcome!”

He had quite the service ethic for someone so young. Hyuk Mujin stepped forward and asked in a dignified voice,

“Do you have any rooms available?”

“Of course, sir. What kind of room would you like?”

“Give us the largest one.”

“Ah, you mean the private annex?”

The inn boy looked us over. Perhaps because all three of us wore martial robes, he chose his next words carefully.

“I’m sorry, but half the fee for the private annex must be paid in advance.”

“Well, aren’t you a shrewd little bastard.”

Hyuk Mujin deliberately hardened his expression and pulled a heavy money pouch from inside his robes. It appeared to be the expense money Jin Wikyung had given him.

“Fine. How much?”

“Fifty nyang[669] for one night, sir.”

How much was fifty nyang?

I had never used money here and didn’t know how the currency worked, so I could only leave it to Hyuk Mujin.

Well, he’ll handle it somehow.

I glanced to the side. Jin Mukyung seemed to be thinking the same thing as me.

Then again, he was a martial arts fanatic and the young master of a wealthy family. Nothing about his background suggested he would have any sense of money.

Hyuk Mujin, a member of the working class, reacted differently.

“What? How much?”

“Fifty nyang, sir.”

[669] A *nyang* is a historical unit of currency. Here the payment is in silver nyang, contrasted with lower-value iron coins.

"…Iron coins?"

"Excuse me?"

The inn boy looked Hyuk Mujin up and down, then gave a short laugh.

"Would you like a different room?"

"…!"

The mockery was unmistakable. Hyuk Mujin's lips trembled before he burst into hearty laughter.

"Ha ha ha! Impressive business sense for such a little brat. A different room? Don't be ridiculous. Hurry up and show us to the private annex."

"You'll have to pay twenty-five nyang first."

"You little—!"

"Whoa!"

The inn boy flinched at Hyuk Mujin's bluster.

That guy only got bullied when he was with us. Despite appearances, he was a First Rate martial artist and a candidate to become the next Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

A commoner who knew nothing about martial arts—and a child barely into his teens at that—could only be frightened.

"I-I'll show you the way right away!"

We followed the thoroughly tense inn boy to the private annex. Along the way, we saw a garden that was, with a little exaggeration, the size of a soccer field, as well as a pond where carp swam.

The annex was divided into three large rooms and decorated with objects that looked expensive even at a glance.

"Wow, this room is nice."

Jin Mukyung nodded as well.

"Not bad. At this size, training won't be a problem."

"…"

Is martial arts the only thing in that guy's head?

While I wandered around sightseeing in the annex, Hyuk Mujin returned after paying for our stay.

"Aren't you two going to eat?"

"I'm fine. Enduring hunger is a form of training, too."

Jin Mukyung answered firmly, then left the annex and disappeared into the garden.

"What about you, Captain?"

"Do I look like that lunatic to you? I'm starving to death. Let's hurry up and order everything they have."

Was it my imagination, or did Hyuk Mujin's face suddenly darken?

The Phoenix Inn was one of Shanxi Province's most famous establishments. There were three reasons for that.

First, it was large enough to accommodate hundreds of people. Second, its dishes were prepared by a former imperial-court chef. And third, there was the beauty of its proprietress.

Despite its steep prices, the Phoenix Inn never lacked customers.

Of course, Hyuk Mujin, who had been born into a family of tenant farmers, had never even dreamed of visiting a place like this.

When else would someone like me ever get the chance?

Half a shichen[670] ago, Hyuk Mujin's mood had reached its peak. A fine room, delicious food, and even the beauty of the proprietress, whom people said could only be seen on lucky days.

And I get to enjoy all of this with someone else's money!

Is this a dream or reality?

Then he heard the price of one night in the private annex and wondered again.

Is this a dream or reality?

The same words. A completely different feeling.

He wished it were a dream, but by the time he came to his senses, it was already too late. He had fallen completely for the inn boy's mockery and even paid the advance fee. It was all over.

All I was given for expenses was fifty nyang.

Fifty silver nyang.

Considering that a family of four could generally live for a year on a little over ten silver nyang, it was an enormous sum.

The problem was that the Phoenix Inn's prices were on an entirely different level from ordinary prices.

I paid twenty-five nyang in advance, so exactly half is left.

Even that money would be gone once the sun rose. Hyuk Mujin was about to spend all the expense money Jin Wikyung had given him on a single night's lodging, and sweat dampened the small of his back.

If that damned inn boy hadn't laughed at me…

Regret always comes too late.

Hyuk Mujin hurriedly began working the abacus in his head.

The expense money is gone. But I brought some emergency savings just in case, so maybe I can somehow manage.

[670] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Five silver nyang. Every coin he had saved until now. He had brought it in case of an emergency, never expecting to actually spend it.

If I don't indulge too much, I should be able to hold out until we return.

But there was one thing Hyuk Mujin had failed to consider.

Jin Taekyung's appetite.

Slurp. Gulp. Munch, munch.

"Wow, this really melts in your mouth."

"…"

Beggar's Chicken,[671] Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork,[672] Maechae Guyuk,[673] scallion tofu, Kung Pao chicken[674]… Every time one of those dishes—or any of the dozen others—arrived at the table, Jin Taekyung's hand moved like lightning.

"Wow, this is really good. So juicy."

"…"

"You're not eating? Then I'll finish the rest too."

"…"

"Wow, this broth is incredible."

"…Please, eat as much as you like."

At some point, a single tear rolled down Hyuk Mujin's cheek.

The dishes served so far already cost five silver nyang.

His last hope was gone. Judging by the way things were going, that pig looked ready to devour another twenty plates.

Hyuk Mujin wanted to smash a plate over the pig-like bastard's head, but he restrained himself. He didn't want to lose his life on top of his entire fortune.

Jade Emperor,[675] Primordial Heavenly Venerable.[676] Please, stop that bastard.

Just as he cursed the heavens—

Crash!

The hardest parts of life in Murim were, first, survival and, second, the food. For some reason, everything was spicy, salty, and greasy, leaving me craving soup at every meal.

In that sense, the dish just placed on the table held special significance.

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[671] Beggar's Chicken is a Chinese dish traditionally made by wrapping and baking a whole chicken.

[672] "Fish-fragrant" names a Chinese seasoning style; the shredded pork dish does not necessarily contain fish.

[673] *Maechae Guyuk* is an abbreviated name for pork belly steamed with preserved mustard greens.

[674] Kung Pao chicken is a Chinese stir-fry of diced chicken, commonly made with peanuts and dried chilies.

[675] The Jade Emperor is a ruler of heaven in Daoist tradition.

[676] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is a high deity in Daoist tradition.

Chicken-and-corn soup.

It was a kind of corn soup with egg whisked through it until silky smooth.

I lowered my head slightly and smelled it. The distinctive savory scent of corn lingered at the tip of my nose.

Yes, this is it.

A smile rose naturally to my face. My stomach had already started feeling greasy. Once I settled it with the chicken-and-corn soup, I could probably clear another ten plates.

All right, then, now…

Just as I grasped the hot ceramic bowl with pleasant anticipation—

Crash! Clatter, clatter!

"…Huh?"

It happened in an instant. A liquor bottle shattered in the middle of the table, exploding into hundreds of ceramic shards that flew in every direction.

Along with them came the little liquor left inside.

Pitter-patter.

Drenched by the sudden shower, I was left speechless.

How could this happen?

The chicken-and-corn soup I had been eagerly awaiting—the warm, savory broth that would gently soothe my stomach—was no longer there.

What now filled the ceramic bowl was nothing more than food waste mixed with liquor and pieces of pottery.

Across from me, Hyuk Mujin stared with his mouth hanging open.

"Oh, Jade Emperor. Primordial Heavenly Venerable."

Ignoring his nonsense, I slowly turned toward the direction the bottle had come from.

Five men were looking our way and snickering.

"Oh, Brother. Sorry about that."

"Who can you blame when your hand slips? We can just order him another one."

"Hey, don't say anything crazy. Didn't you see how much that bastard's been eating?"

I watched them snicker among themselves, then crooked a finger.

The one who had apologized first. That bastard was the culprit who had ruined my chicken-and-corn soup.

"What, you want me to come over?"

He gave a short laugh, rose from his seat, and strode toward us.

His martial robes reeked of sweat and blood, and a curved saber hung from his left hip. That was the source of his confidence.

All right. Let's handle this rationally.

I spoke calmly.

"The ancient sages said that even a dog shouldn't be disturbed while it's eating. Apologize properly and order the food again. Starting with the chicken-and-corn soup."

"Well, listen to the little brat lisp."

"What about the apology?"

"Come on, kid. Stick out your tongue. I'll pull it out for you."

He grinned, revealing teeth rotted black.

The horrific stench of his breath wiped away my appetite as if it had been washed clean. I supposed I would have to eat the chicken-and-corn soup later.

"Open your mouth. My fist is going in."

As the words left my mouth, I drove my fist into his face.

Crack!

There were three reasons the Phoenix Inn was famous.

But the third was why so many people—men in particular—flocked there.

The beautiful proprietress, whom one could only meet on a lucky day.

And today was that day.

"It's noisy."

The proprietress's clear yet languid voice was not directed at herself. The presence outside her door vanishing proved it.

A moment later, a quiet voice came from beyond the door.

"A fight has broken out between martial artists."

The proprietress clicked her tongue softly before speaking.

"Did anyone die?"

"One man subdued the other six."

"Who is he? Where is he from?"

"He's the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

The proprietress laughed soundlessly.

"What a welcome name. I should go see his face after all this time."

She rose from where she had been reclining. Moonlight filtering through the window gleamed upon her slender, long-stemmed tobacco pipe.

Chapter 105

Crack!

The instant my fist sank into that foul-smelling snout, I knew.

The only thing that bastard would be able to eat from now on was chicken-and-corn soup.

Crash! Bang!

The first man shot straight backward and lost consciousness before he even hit the ground.

Level 31. He was a martial artist who had just entered the First Rate, but he still couldn't dodge my punch.

"Where the fuck do you get off breathing that stench all over the place and ruining my appetite?"

Every sound in the inn stopped.

But only for a moment.

"Gwangsu's down!"

"You little bastard!"

"Kill him!"

Shing, shing, shing!

Five curved sabers were drawn at once. Five pairs of eyes gleamed with killing intent. The inn's guests scattered, screaming.

I suddenly remembered the smell of blood coming from the man who had just fallen.

Huh. Look at these bastards.

They were used to killing. I could tell from the way they had started the fight, yet hadn't hesitated for a moment to draw their weapons.

"What are you people?"

"The Grim Reaper."

The answer came as they charged.

Four curved sabers thrust toward my limbs, while the remaining one aimed precisely at my chest.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

Too slow.

One of the five was First Rate. The other four were Second Rate.

Their plan to take me down was ambitious, but their feet were slow, and the net of sabers they spread from the front was full of gaps.

"Next time, at least try surrounding your opponent."

With that friendly advice, I flicked both hands toward them.

In a very brief instant, two daggers summoned from my Inventory sliced through the air.

Whoosh!

Dagger throwing. Do they call it flying-dagger arts in Murim?

I had never learned it for actual combat, but that was fine. Blade or hilt, all that mattered was hitting them.

Crack! Thud.

Yes, just like that.

The hilt of a dagger split one man's forehead, and he crumpled without even managing to scream.

What about the other one?

Clang!

"What a cheap trick!"

Whether he was lucky or had sharper eyes than I expected, he somehow managed to block it.

I gave him a broad smile.

"Is that dagger yours?"

"You threw it at me! What kind of bullshit are you talking about?"

"What an honest boy. As a reward, I'll give you both of them."

Thud, thud!

"Ghk. But your hands were clearly empty…"

Thud.

"My daggers multiply infinitely."

Stopping by the armory before leaving the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been a good idea.

I had gone in empty-handed and come out empty-handed, but my Inventory was now filled with dozens of weapons looted as spoils.

"What… what is this?"

It had all happened in the blink of an eye. The remaining three men stopped midcharge, faltered, and backed away.

"Not coming? Then I'll come to you."

"W-Wait, Young Hero! We were rude. We sincerely apologize and will compensate you…"

Look how quickly they changed their tune.

A moment ago, they had been calling me a little bastard. Now I was Young Hero.

"An apology?"

"Yes, yes!"

"Don't need it!"

I clenched my fist and charged at them. I didn't need martial arts to deal with bastards like these.

"Damn it! Get him!"

Whoosh!

One step to the side.

I dodged the curved saber chopping straight down at the crown of my head, then drove a single punch into the opening at his side.

Crunch.

Leaving him to collapse with a strangled groan, I charged at the next opponent. A System window above his head displayed Level 35.

"You bastard!"

Whoosh!

As befitted a First Rate master, he had clearly learned a fair amount of martial arts. His movements were clean, and his curved saber swept precisely toward my vital points.

But…

All of it is useless against overwhelming strength and speed.

My level and internal energy were low, but my stats far surpassed those of a First Rate martial artist. Add the combat experience I had built up in Murim, and this man was no match for me.

Crack!

The focus vanished from his eyes. The curved saber slipped from his grip before he could finish his swing.

Clang.

The last man, who had watched everything unfold, was half out of his mind.

"T-The Captain fell in a single exchange… Who are you?"

"You should exchange names with my fist. Here, this one's called Right Hand. And you?"

I raised my clenched right fist and approached. The man swung his curved saber wildly through the air.

"D-Don't come any closer!"

"You should ask more politely."

"Please, don't come any closer!"

"You actually did it."

Well, if he was going to ask that politely, I ought to grant his request.

When I stopped walking, color returned to the man's face.

"T-Thank you! I'll live a good life from now on!"

"No need to thank me. And you don't have to live a good life."

"Huh?"

"Turning over a new leaf isn't that easy. Right, Mujin?"

Hyuk Mujin was standing behind the man before I knew it.

"Of course."

"Gasp!"

The man sucked in a startled breath and turned around, but it was already too late.

Hyuk Mujin was in the middle of bringing the wooden chair in his hands down on the crown of the man's head with all his strength.

Crack!

The last man collapsed with a heavy thud. Hyuk Mujin set down the chair and muttered,

"Thanks, and sorry."

"What are you thanking those bastards for?"

"There are things."

That look in his eyes was awfully cocky.

I was wondering whether I should give him a smack after such a long time when Hyuk Mujin, who had been searching through the fallen men's clothes, tilted his head.

"Huh? Captain, there's something suspicious about these men."

"What?"

"Look at this."

Hyuk Mujin rolled up one man's sleeve, revealing what looked like a scar left by a branding iron.

No, it wasn't just a scar.

It looked like…

"A tattoo?"

Crude and savage as it was, it was definitely a kind of tattoo.

One shaped like a running horse.

"Is he the only one with it?"

"I don't know. I haven't checked them all yet."

"Check the others."

"Yes, sir."

Hyuk Mujin gathered the unconscious men in one place and stripped off their shirts.

Arms, chests, necks. The locations differed slightly, but every one of them bore a horse tattoo.

So they belong to some kind of organization…

I already knew they weren't simple thugs. Two of them were First Rate masters, and the word the last man had let slip without meaning to kept bothering me.

He definitely said Captain, didn't he?

Were they martial artists from another sect?

No. Their aura was too rough for that, and their clothing wasn't uniform.

A sizable band of wandering martial artists seemed more likely.

A horse tattoo. A horse tattoo…

Then a word suddenly flashed through my mind.

It was a name I had first heard during the war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

"Mounted bandits?"

Someone answered my mutter from somewhere nearby.

"There are dozens of mounted-bandit groups in northern Gaoyuan. It was a great mistake for Lee Cheonbaek to hire them."

I turned toward the owner of the languid yet alluring voice.

A woman stood on the stairs leading to the second floor, a veil draped across her face.

"Long time no see, our Young Master."

Our Young Master?

The moment I heard those words, I knew who she was.

Wolhwa.

It was her.

Hyuk Mujin and I were led to a guest room on the top floor of the Phoenix Inn.

Calling it a guest room hardly did it justice. It occupied the entire floor, so penthouse would have been more accurate.

"It's my first time bringing a man here. And two of them, no less."

Bathed in the soft light, Wolhwa's smile was dazzling.

I had felt it from the moment we first met, but she was the very definition of a femme fatale.

Even after meeting her several times, the sight of her was enough to make my stomach churn. Hyuk Mujin was beyond saving.

"I-It is the honor of three lifetimes."

"…"

Look at that bastard's glazed eyes.

He was completely smitten.

Wolhwa gave him a smile, then turned her gaze toward me.

“Have you been well, Young Master Jin? Ah, perhaps I can’t call you Young Master the way I used to anymore?”

The mischief in her expression made it obvious what was coming. I hurriedly waved my hands.

“Just call me whatever you like. Like before.”

“Hmm. Then how about Young Master Sleeping Dragon?”

“…That’s horrible.”

“Oh my, why? Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi sounds wonderful. If you’ve earned that much martial fame at such a young age, you could stand to be a little prouder.”

Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Flaming Charisma Taekyung—six of one, half a dozen of the other.

Seeing my expression, Wolhwa chuckled and put her long-stemmed tobacco pipe to her lips.

“I’m only joking. Anyway, teasing Young Master Jin is so much fun.”

“Excuse me for interrupting.”

Hyuk Mujin had regained some of his senses. He looked back and forth between Wolhwa and me.

“May I ask what kind of relationship the two of you have?”

“None of your business.”

Our relationship was too embarrassing to explain in detail.

I cut him off sharply and glanced at Wolhwa, signaling for her to play along.

Quick on the uptake, she nodded.

“He used to be a regular at my establishment. Not anymore, though.”

“…”

Like hell she understood.

Then again, after how openly she had acted in front of Jin Wikyung and Wipeng, it would have been ridiculous for her to hide it now.

Hyuk Mujin, meanwhile, seemed only half-convinced by Wolhwa’s answer.

“By ‘establishment,‘ do you mean the Phoenix Inn?”

“No. This is just a side business. My real profession is something only a beautiful and charming woman like me can do.”

“Then perhaps…”

“It’s probably exactly what you’re imagining, Young Martial Artist.”

“A pleasure house?”

“Correct.”

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes widened.

“So the proprietress of the Phoenix Inn, whom I had only heard about in rumors, was a courtesan.”

“Young Martial Artist, you should watch your words. That isn’t very pleasant to hear.”

“If I offended you, I apologize. However, your words and behavior don’t exactly appear in a favorable light either.”

His sudden seriousness caught me even more off guard.

“Hey, what’s with you?”

“Captain—no, Young Master—is a direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Even the most beautiful woman under heaven has no right to treat him so casually. As a retainer of our family, I could not simply stand by and watch.”

“A moment ago, you said this was the honor of three lifetimes.”

“…In any case, how dare a mere courtesan treat the Young Master—agh!”

I gave him a satisfying whack on the back of the head.

“She’s the Shanxi Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect.”

“Shanxi Branch Leader or not—what? What did you say?”

“Are your ears clogged? I said she’s the Shanxi Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect. She gave us extremely—very, very—decisive help in the recent war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

“I’m fine, Young Master Jin.”

Wolhwa lowered her eyes sadly.

“I’m only a mere courtesan, after all.”

Hyuk Mujin fell silent for a moment, then bowed his head.

“Young Lady—no, Branch Leader. I apologize…”

“Then keep your mouth shut.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

Wolhwa let out a quiet laugh.

“You have an interesting subordinate.”

As the saying went, it was the squid that disgraced the fish market. That bastard Hyuk Mujin was disgracing the entire Jin Family of Taiyuan all by himself.

I was too embarrassed to even look Wolhwa in the eye.

“…I apologize for all of this.”

“You’re not the one who needs to apologize, Young Master. And he wasn’t entirely wrong.”

Thankfully, she let it slide without a fuss.

After exhaling a stream of smoke, Wolhwa spoke.

“You’re on your way to the Mount Heng Sword Sect, aren’t you?”

“Yes.”

“May I ask what your purpose is?”

“You already know, don’t you?”

She was the greatest source of information in all of Shanxi Province. There was no need to ask how she knew.

“I wanted Young Master Jin to tell me himself… I’m disappointed.”

“Business and personal matters should be kept separate.”

“How cold. Then may I make a proposal? Or a deal, if you prefer.”

“I’ll decide after I hear it.”

Wolhwa tapped the ash from her pipe.

“Let’s go together. To the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

“What?”

What the hell was she talking about?

Chapter 106

“Let’s go together. To the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

“What?”

“You heard me, Young Master Jin. I have business at the Mount Heng Sword Sect too.”

“What kind of business?”

“I don’t think I can tell you that. I’m rather clear about keeping business and personal matters separate myself.”

Talk about getting paid back tenfold.

My own words had come straight back to bite me. Wolhwa’s smile deepened as she watched me grow awkward.

“I’m only joking. I happen to have something to collect from the Mount Heng Sword Sect. More precisely, something I’m supposed to receive from the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“What… Oh.”

A memory suddenly came to me. Back when the war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect was in full swing, the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Lower District Sect had made a secret pact.

Hadn’t we promised them ownership of the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s properties and other holdings in exchange for information?

The Lower District Sect—or rather, Wolhwa—had kept her promise. It was thanks to her help that we had been able to annihilate the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s vanguard early in the war.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had continued receiving help from the Lower District Sect afterward and eventually won the war, but that was when the trouble began.

“As you know, Young Master Jin, our position has become rather awkward. We won the war, but we can’t lay our hands on the spoils.”

The strong devouring the weak. That was the law of Murim.

But the appearance of the Head Elder had ruined everything. The moment it came to light that the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect had both been manipulated by him, the justification for claiming the spoils had grown faint.

So that’s why we’re pursuing a merger.

Now was the time to sheathe our swords and negotiate with a brush. Jin Wikyung’s vision was to quietly and amicably absorb the Mount Heng Sword Sect within limits that would keep the world from condemning us.

Wolhwa wanted her reward before that happened.

“If the Mount Heng Sword Sect accepts our proposal, couldn’t you demand your reward then?”

"That would only be possible if the Jin Family of Taiyuan were Shanxi's hegemon rather than its Alliance Leader. If you tried to seize anything rashly in the current situation, the other small and mid-sized sects would pull out too. Besides…"

For a moment, she gave me a meaningful look, then shook her head.

What was that supposed to mean?

"Besides what?"

"No, it's nothing. Anyway, I did receive a proposal from the Lesser Family Head."

Wolhwa took a puff from her long-stemmed tobacco pipe before continuing.

"He said he would transfer wealth equivalent to what he had promised, or hand over some of the areas managed by the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

That sounded reasonable enough, but it looked different from the perspective of someone leading an organization rather than acting as an individual.

She wants to expand her territory.

Wolhwa was neither a courtesan nor an innkeeper at heart. She was an information merchant.

She clearly wanted to use this opportunity to expand the Lower District Sect's influence into northern Shanxi, where the Mount Heng Sword Sect's blockade had kept it relatively weak.

Jin Wikyung, naturally, wants the Jin Family of Taiyuan to encompass all of Shanxi.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had already wielded enormous influence over central and southern Shanxi for a long time. Handing over a few prime territories wouldn't diminish what they had built.

This is exactly like a redevelopment zone.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect, which had held the north in an iron grip and blocked outside forces from entering, was collapsing. The greenbelt had been lifted and the area opened for redevelopment, kicking off a tug-of-war between Jin Wikyung and Wolhwa.

They're both something else.

Yesterday's ally had become today's competitor.

Once again, I was reminded that there was always more to people than met the eye.

"So I thought I'd meet our adorable new Sect Leader and collect what I'm owed while I was at it. How about we travel to the Mount Heng Sword Sect together?"

I answered without another thought.

"I'll have to decline."

"Wow, aren't you being a little too decisive? You cut me off without even hearing the terms."

"As his younger brother, I can't go around splashing filth on my hyung's[677] path."

[677] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

We might not have shared a drop of blood, but I had long since accepted his existence—and this Murim—as my own.

"Hmm."

Wolhwa stared at me for a moment before setting her pipe down with a sharp tap.

"All right, then."

"Ah. Yes."

I had expected her to tempt me a few more times, but she gave up right away.

Well, I was glad the conversation had ended quickly. That made things easier for me.

"Then we'll be going."

I gave Hyuk Mujin, who was still sitting there with his mouth sealed shut, a light tap and rose from my seat. That was when Wolhwa smiled strangely and spoke.

"Oh, could you tell Jin Mukyung something for me? The old pines in the rear courtyard are expensive, so please ask him to be careful while training."

This was an inn run by the greatest information merchant in Shanxi. Ever since we entered this place, she had probably seen right through us, down to our innards.

"Sure."

"And tell me if you need anything. It's a request from our Young Master Jin, so I have to procure anything you might need."

She winked. I glanced at her and left the room, only to remember something I had momentarily forgotten.

"Mujin, why do you run your mouth so carelessly?"

Whack! Whack! Whack!

"Argh! Argh! Argh!"

One of us hit, and the other took the hits.

When we returned to the private residence, several old pine trees stood neatly severed, with Jin Mukyung waiting beside them looking thoroughly satisfied.

"There's a certain satisfaction to cutting."

"…"

"…"

One day, I really want to cut that bastard down.

The guest room fell quiet. Wolhwa smoked her long-stemmed tobacco pipe for a long while, and it was only well after Jin Taekyung had left that she finally spoke.

"Did you look into what I instructed you to investigate?"

A member of the Lower District Sect who had been waiting outside the room answered in a low voice.

“What you confirmed four days ago is all we have. We’re still gathering additional information, but…”

“Nothing else is going to turn up?”

“It’s unlikely.”

“Unlikely? Then there’s still a chance. Keep digging. I’ll give you plenty of time, so don’t rush. You know we won’t come out of it well either if we provoke the Jin Family of Taiyuan right now.”

“Yes, Branch Leader.”

The Lower District Sect member was about to withdraw when Wolhwa stopped him with one more question.

“A Third Rate wastrel became the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi in less than two months. What do you think?”

“It’s possible, if the rumors are true.”

“Ah, that.”

Wolhwa let out a short, incredulous laugh. The rumor had begun spreading after Jin Taekyung defeated Jopil, One Question, One Kill.

According to the rumor, everything Jin Taekyung had shown until then had been an act. In truth, he had trained in martial arts from childhood with the family’s full support.

By now, the story had spread so widely that there was hardly anyone in Shanxi who hadn’t heard it.

“Do you believe it?”

“It’s ridiculous nonsense. But…”

“People believe it. Not because they’re stupid, but because they have no choice but to believe it. But we’re different.”

Shanxi was a remote frontier the Central Plains barely even acknowledged, but the Lower District Sect had never stopped gathering information there.

That went without saying when it came to the direct descendants of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, one of Shanxi’s most powerful families. Their only mistake had been failing to accurately assess the Head Elder, who had been active during the chaotic period of war.

But their information on Jin Taekyung was nearly perfect.

“Alcohol, women, gambling. He was lazy from childhood and cared about nothing but having fun. He was so out of place that you had to wonder whether anyone like him had ever existed in the history of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“That was the first order you gave after taking office as Branch Leader two years ago.”

"That's right. Monitor the entire situation in Shanxi. And investigate Jin Taekyung in depth."

Talent tended to run in families. The direct descendants of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had possessed exceptional martial talent for generations, and the current Family Head and his two sons, all regarded as eccentrics, were no exception.

Jin Taekyung stood out among them as something almost alien. That was why the Lower District Sect had begun its investigation.

"The result was anticlimactic."

"He was exactly what he appeared to be."

Other than slightly superior bones, sinews, and meridians—perhaps thanks to his bloodline—there was nothing special about him.

"Did we miss something back then?"

"He was the kind of bastard who spent every other night at a pleasure house. Martial arts take more time than anyone has, even if they cut back on sleep."

"I know. I know very well."

Wolhwa had cultivated her martial arts to a fairly mature stage even within the First Rate realm. There was no way she didn't understand that.

She drew repeatedly on her pipe in frustration, then released a long breath.

"In the end, there's only one answer."

"That's right."

Jin Taekyung had gone from Third Rate to a Supreme First Rate master in a little over two months. Wolhwa was dumbfounded by the conclusion she had reached herself, but there was nothing she could do about it.

"Forget the order I gave earlier. Don't ask about him anymore, and don't try to learn anything else. Issue a gag order and make sure no one even mentions this."

"Yes, Branch Leader. I'll make sure they understand."

"Oh, and one more thing. I'll be leaving early tomorrow, so make the preparations."

"Who are you planning to take with you?"

"No one. I'll go alone."

"Branch Leader, that…"

"It's an order."

"Understood."

Once her subordinate withdrew, silence settled over the guest room. Wolhwa tapped the blackened tobacco leaves from her pipe and thought.

Jin Taekyung.

If everything he had done until now was true, then the northern interests she needed to extract from the Mount Heng Sword Sect were nothing.

Has anyone in all history ever grown this quickly?

Her gaze darkened as she stared at the place where Jin Taekyung had been sitting.

The next morning.

I began to feel that something had gone wrong after meeting the person in charge of the private residence.

“The lodging fee is twenty-five nyang,[678] the food comes to five nyang,[679] and the property damage fee is fifty nyang.[680] The total is eighty silver nyang.[681]”

Hyuk Mujin, who had been celebrating yesterday after emptying those mounted bandits’ pockets, gaped.

“Property damage? Fifty silver nyang?[682]”

“When I went to the rear courtyard, I found that five old pine trees had fallen.”

They were the trees Wolhwa had said were expensive.

Hyuk Mujin and I turned our heads at the same time. Jin Mukyung, whose eyes met ours, flinched before opening his mouth.

“I got carried away while practicing my swordsmanship.”

“…No, fuck. If you get carried away, does that mean you can cut down anything in your way? Huh?”

“Hoooo.”

Hyuk Mujin couldn’t say anything. He merely let out one furious sigh after another.

One look told me the bill exceeded the money we had left. If it had only been a little over, maybe we could have talked it out and found some middle ground…

“Mujin, how much do you have right now?”

“Forty nyang.[683]”

Middle ground, my ass. We’re nowhere close.

“Could we put it on credit?”

That was the exact moment the kind smile around the private-residence manager’s lips disappeared.

“Young Master Jin, what are you doing here?”

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[678] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of money. Here, the bill distinguishes silver nyang from the amount owed in lower-value iron coins.

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A beautiful woman in a light, flowing palace-style dress was approaching us.

Right now, Wolhwa's appearance was nothing short of a lifeline.

I felt bad about turning down her proposal so decisively the night before, but this was no time to be picky.

"Well, you see…"

When I explained the situation, Wolhwa's eyes grew round.

"Eighty nyang?[684] That can't be right."

"Exactly. I knew something was wrong."

"Give me that."

She took the bamboo slip from the manager and began to read.

The deeper her frown grew, the clearer it seemed that the arithmetic had been badly botched.

Knew it.

At last, Wolhwa finished reading the bamboo slip. A chill entered her voice.

"Are you not doing your job properly?"

"I-I'm sorry."

"Do you have any idea who these gentlemen are? How dare you pull this kind of stunt? Write down the correct prices."

Hyuk Mujin whispered to me.

"What a relief."

"Yeah. We almost had to wash dishes before leaving."

"Why do we have to suffer because of the Second Young Master?"

"Don't even mention that man. Just hearing about him gives me cancer."

"What's cancer?"

"…Something bad."

Meanwhile, the manager revised the prices, sweating profusely. Then he bowed deeply and apologized to us.

"I'm sorry. I acted thoughtlessly and committed a grave discourtesy."

Hyuk Mujin accepted the apology with an arrogant air.

"Don't do that again. You have to know who you're dealing with before pulling a prank. So how much is it?"

"One hundred and five silver nyang[685] and twenty-three nyang[686] in iron coins."

"…?"

"…?"

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[684] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of money. Here, the bill distinguishes silver nyang from the amount owed in lower-value iron coins.

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[686] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of money. Here, the bill distinguishes silver nyang from the amount owed in lower-value iron coins.

What the hell? Is this a dream?

My head turned toward Wolhwa of its own accord.

“What is that supposed to mean?”

“He arbitrarily lowered the prices because you were my acquaintances. How dare he look down on the young masters of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan? Apologize again.”

“I’m sorry for failing to recognize your identities!”

“But…”

I asked in a thoroughly choked voice.

“We can put it on credit, right? Of course.”

“No, you can’t. Of course not. We haven’t allowed that even once in the past two years.”

“How about making an exception and setting a precedent this time?”

“I don’t have any plans to do that yet. You’ll have to aim for the next opportunity.”

Wolhwa added with a radiant smile,

“Was there something else you wanted to say?”

“…M-Mount Heng.”

“What was that?”

I squeezed my eyes shut and continued.

“Would you like to come with us to the Mount Heng Sword Sect?”

“Wow, I’d love to.”

That hateful smile.

At Wolhwa’s gesture, the manager snatched up the bamboo slip and vanished at the speed of light.

“We won’t have to worry about travel expenses anymore.”

While Hyuk Mujin was the sort of person who simply accepted reality, someone else was shouting vehement opposition.

“Nonsense! How can you bring a woman along while carrying out a family mission?”

“Then stay here and wash dishes.”

“…”

“Who here cut down the old pine trees? Raise your hand.”

Jin Mukyung didn’t raise his hand. Wolhwa slightly lifted the hem of her skirt and greeted him.

“Please take good care of me, Young Hero Jin.”

Chapter 107

The four-horse carriage rolled smoothly toward our destination. Though the horses and carriage were the same as yesterday, the difference in ride quality was night and day.

We had a new driver.

Having finally escaped the driver's seat and settled beside me, Hyuk Mujin said with a carefree expression, "I guess everyone has their own natural talents. I'm hopeless at driving a carriage."

Hopeless, my ass.

This was a man Wolhwa, the Lower District Sect's Shanxi Branch Leader, had brought with her. Naturally, he was no ordinary coachman.

The man silently holding the reins was a Level 50 First Rate martial artist. A coachman and a bodyguard—the picture fit perfectly.

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Please, just keep quiet. Then you'll at least do okay."

"…Why am I always the one you pick on?"

"Because you're always spouting nonsense, you idiot."

Wolhwa, who was sitting across from us and watching, let out a quiet laugh.

"It's nice to see how comfortable you two are with each other."

"He just has no respect."

"No respect? I wasn't going to bring this up, but I'm two years older than you, Captain. Some of my friends already have children."

"You don't."

"Well, no. That's true."

"And even if you were twenty-two, you'd still be younger than me. Anyway, you're younger."

"What are you talking about? Even the stray dogs of Shanxi Province know you've only just turned twenty."

"If you don't believe me, fight me."

"…Since we have company, I'll leave it at that."

Wolhwa beamed at Hyuk Mujin's ugly excuse.

"Oh, I don't mind. Though I can't speak for Jin Mukyung over here."

Everyone's eyes naturally turned toward one person.

Jin Mukyung, who had kept his mouth firmly shut until now, flinched before speaking.

"I-I don't mind."

"…?"

What the hell? Did he just stutter?

My eyes widened at the unexpected response, and Jin Mukyung subtly looked away.

Oh, this is getting worse.

He wasn't usually like this. Normally, he would have glared and demanded to know what I was staring at.

I asked him sincerely, "Are you sick?"

"…Not at all."

"You should look people in the eye when you talk to them."

"…Shut up. Don't talk to me."

He was acting really strange today.

There was no way a Peak master like him had gotten motion sickness.

He had been full of energy until this morning, but now he was clearly not himself.

Come to think of it, he seems to have been like this ever since we got into the carriage.

Just as I was narrowing my eyes and watching Jin Mukyung—

Poke, poke.

Hyuk Mujin nudged me in the side and whispered so quietly that only I could hear.

"Look at the Second Young Master."

"What about him…? Ah."

Only after hearing Hyuk Mujin did I notice the bizarre sight.

I couldn't believe I had missed it until now.

What is he doing?

The four-horse carriage brought from the Jin Family of Taiyuan was quite luxurious. The interior was about the size of an ordinary room, with seats spacious enough to accommodate twice our number without trouble.

And yet…

Why is he sitting like that?

Despite all the available space, Jin Mukyung had crammed himself into the farthest corner of the carriage. No, *crammed* didn't quite cover it. He was practically compressed.

What is this, Platform Nine and Three-Quarters?

Was he attending a magic school instead of Heaven's Gate Temple?

Hyuk Mujin and I weren't the only ones watching his strange behavior.

"Young Hero Jin, you look very uncomfortable. Why don't you come over here? There's plenty of room."

Jin Mukyung went rigid at the sound of Wolhwa's alluring voice.

His creaking reply came a moment later.

“I-I’m fine.”

“…”

He didn’t look fine at all.

I quietly whispered to Hyuk Mujin, who wore an expression much like mine.

“You think he’s acting strange too, right?”

“This goes beyond strange.”

“Yeah, that’s what I thought.”

We exchanged meaningful glances.

“My goodness. Who would’ve imagined?”

“Exactly. Who knew the great Heaven Shaking Sword was so shy around strangers?”

“That’s exactly what I—huh?”

“Why are you reacting like that? You shouldn’t criticize someone for their personality. If there are thick-skinned bastards like me, there can be timid people too.”

“No, wait. Just wait a moment.”

Hyuk Mujin stumbled over his words.

“What exactly are you talking about?”

“Obviously, Jin Mukyung…”

An eerie voice suddenly cut in.

“Shut up.”

No matter how spacious it was, we were still inside a carriage. Everyone could hear us.

Faced with Jin Mukyung’s murderous glare, Hyuk Mujin and I shut our mouths at the same time.

Wolhwa was the one who dispelled the grim atmosphere.

“Where are my manners? I haven’t properly introduced myself yet. I’m Wolhwa, Shanxi Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect.”

“…I am Jin Mukyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“What a dull reaction. Young Master Jin over there was extremely surprised when he first learned who I was.”

“I heard the general details from him. I also heard that you rendered our family a great service.”

Jin Mukyung politely clasped his hands.

“Though it comes late, allow me to express my gratitude.”

“Not at all. It was a fair transaction.”

Wolhwa smoothly added, “Though I have yet to receive proper compensation.”

“Our family will not forget the Lower District Sect’s goodwill.”

His behavior and manner of speaking were still awkward beyond belief, but he was doing much better than when they had first met.

Looking at the handsome man and beautiful woman sitting together like a picture, Hyuk Mujin exclaimed,

“A promising young martial arts master and a peerless beauty… Whew, just looking at them makes my heart race. Don’t you agree?”

I turned away and pretended not to hear him.

Judging by the killing intent prickling my skin, Hyuk Mujin’s heart wouldn’t be racing much longer.

Winter days were short-tempered.

How long had we traveled along the mountain road? The sun quickly set, and darkness descended. The carriage stopped two shichen[687] later, around midnight.

“We’ve arrived.”

The first thing I saw upon stepping out of the carriage was a moderately sized wooden building.

A chill greeted me the moment I entered. A statue in human form gazed solemnly down at us.

What did they call places like this again?

Oh, right. A shrine.

I had heard they were places where the spirit tablets of the dead were enshrined and memorial rites performed.

The Guandi Temples[688] that appeared at the drop of a hat in martial arts novels came to mind. I examined the statue, but I couldn’t tell who it depicted.

“This shrine was abandoned after a famine several years ago, but it seems the local commoners still visit from time to time.”

Just as Wolhwa had said, the shrine’s interior was bare, but signs of human presence remained—footprints in the dust covering the floor, for instance.

“I’ll prepare the place.”

At the words of the coachman and bodyguard, whom I assumed to be a member of the Lower District Sect, we headed outside.

More precisely, one of us was dragged out by someone.

“Follow me.”

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[687] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

[688] Guandi Temples are shrines dedicated to Guan Yu, a historical Chinese general later revered as a deity.

“Gah! Captain! Captain!”

I ignored Hyuk Mujin as Jin Mukyung dragged him away by the collar and looked up at the sky.

Hmm. The moon sure is bright tonight.

“What are you doing?”

“As you can see.”

Wolhwa smiled faintly.

“You seem to enjoy looking at the scenery.”

“I’ve been getting into it lately.”

The only scenery to be found in the modern world was the nightscape seen from some high vantage point. Even that consisted of sad lights created by office workers working overtime.

Now this is real scenery.

There were no dense forests of skyscrapers, apartment complexes, or industrial sites.

In place of asphalt roads, damp dirt paths and crisp air filled the entire world.

Living in a place like this would be genuinely healing.

The problem was that it was also an easy place to get killed.

Somehow, people were more frightening here than monsters.

I didn’t even need to go as far as the Head Elder or Jopil. What had happened at the Phoenix Inn just yesterday was enough.

“Oh, right. What happened to those guys?”

“If you mean the mounted bandits from the Red Wind Band, they’ve been detained. Of course, we had to call a physician first.”

I’d beaten the shit out of them, so of course they’d needed treatment.

But there was another word that caught my attention more than that.

“The Red Wind Band?”

“They’re a rising power from Gaoyuan. They’re fairly large, and more than anything, the Red Wind Band Leader is said to possess formidable martial arts.”

Northern Gaoyuan.

I had first learned of that place from a map during the war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

One thing puzzled me. Gaoyuan was a considerable distance from Honju, where the Phoenix Inn was located. As far as I knew, the journey took more than a week even if you rode day and night.

“How did people like that end up all the way here?”

“Toward the end of the war, Lee Cheonbaek hired countless wandering martial artists and mounted-bandit groups. Many of them met their end at Eight Spring Gorge, but some survived and fled.”

"So the Red Wind Band was among them?"

Wolhwa shook her head.

"The Red Wind Band Leader… He was quicker-witted than I expected."

"Then what happened?"

"He watched the situation until the very end. He kept a close eye on Eight Spring Gorge from only two shichen[689] away, then turned his horse around the moment he heard how the battle had ended—along with the two hundred men under his command."

Two hundred people.

What would have happened if the Red Wind Band had joined the battle at Eight Spring Gorge that day? There would have been an enormous number of casualties, and it might even have affected the outcome of the battle.

"We were lucky."

"We were. For the Mount Heng Sword Sect, it was incredibly unlucky."

Wolhwa continued as she firmly packed tobacco leaves into her long-stemmed pipe.

"The Red Wind Band headed north immediately. They targeted the Mount Heng Sword Sect's main base after most of its forces had withdrawn."

"…Huh."

They were natural-born plunderers.

The moment the tide of the war turned, they headed north and sank their teeth into the Mount Heng Sword Sect's throat while most of its main force was away.

They had preserved their forces by staying out of the battle, and they must have been well-rested too. They would have been in peak condition.

"Young Master Jin, you heard how it ended, didn't you?"

"Yes."

After two days of fierce fighting, the Mount Heng Sword Sect ultimately emerged victorious—but at the cost of the Young Sect Leader, who was supposed to succeed his father.

"But the rumors I heard said that wandering martial artists and mounted bandits were mixed together."

"A tiger doesn't become a dog just because it has lost its teeth. The Red Wind Band Leader had recruited quite a few wandering martial artists as well. They would have made excellent shields."

Tap, tap.

Wolhwa took out a fire starter, lit it, and drew on her long-stemmed pipe.

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[689] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

“The mounted bandits Young Master Jin defeated were probably the ones who fled at that time. Even if the Red Wind Band is unusually disciplined for a mounted-bandit group, it doesn’t mean they have no deserters at all. I’m not sure what they were doing in Honju, though.”

“Deserters…”

“That’s why the surrounding area has been so unsettled lately. Wandering martial artists, bandits, mounted bandits, even dark-path figures—they’re all starting to rear their heads now that the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s strength has been so badly diminished.”

“They’ll have no choice but to accept our proposal.”

Wolhwa gave me a prim smile.

“Strictly speaking, it isn’t *our* proposal. It’s the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s, isn’t it? Still, from my perspective, this is certainly a good time to pressure the new Sect Leader.”

“By the way…”

“Yes?”

“Do commoners really visit this shrine in weather like this?”

“Of course not. Hunters, perhaps. Why do you ask all of a sudden?”

I pointed toward the mountain path.

Through the light snowstorm that had begun to swirl, I could see torches climbing toward us.

Chapter 108

Hunters?

Wolhwa's guess was only half right. They were hunters, all right—but the uninvited guests were something more special and far more vicious.

"Move it, you bastards."

"What good are grown men this scrawny?"

There were ten of them in all, every one of them rough-faced and armed. Ahead of them staggered a line of prisoners strung together with rope like dried fish.

Thud! Thud-thud!

"Ugh, Boss!"

"We're moving! We're moving, so please stop…"

"Hah, stop? You bastards still haven't learned your lesson."

"Hey, don't hit them too hard. If something breaks, their price drops. They're already so small we probably won't get full value for them."

"We should get a decent price if we sell them to a circus troupe. Let's hurry inside and have some strong liquor."

"Ah, my mouth's watering just thinking about it… But what's that?"

The human hunters stopped dead. Their eyes lingered on the four-horse carriage parked before the shrine, then slowly shifted aside.

Their gazes came to rest on Wolhwa and me.

"…Who are you?"

I stepped forward when the apparent leader spoke.

"Just a traveler passing through."

"A traveler, huh? Dangerous time to be wandering around."

The oily gleam in his eyes said he himself was one of those dangers.

Of course, at a mere Level 25, he didn't even qualify as a threat to me.

"Would you look at that. A four-horse carriage and a stunning beauty. You must be the Young Master of some wealthy family."

If he had come closer to inspect it, he could have seen the crest of the Jin Family of Taiyuan carved into the carriage. But it was pitch-black outside, and he didn't possess particularly sharp eyesight.

"I'm not from a poor one."

"Well now. You've been awfully informal with me from the start."

The leader licked his cracked lips. He seemed to be getting irritated, but he still hadn't let down his guard around me.

"Whatever. We've been staying here for the past few days… So what are you going to do?"

“About what?”

“What do you think? If you show us a little sincerity, we might let you have the place.”

“Anyone listening would think you owned this shrine.”

“It’s abandoned. Doesn’t that mean whoever claims it first owns it?”

“Then bring me a certified deed.”

“What?”

The leader turned to his men in bewilderment. Naturally, it was probably the first time any of them had heard the term. Not that his men were likely to know any better.

I clicked my tongue as they whispered among themselves about certified deeds.

“If you can’t prove you own it, leave quietly. And untie those people.”

“…You’re crossing the line. Are you waiting for bodyguards?”

“I don’t have any.”

“Then what are you relying on?”

“Me.”

The leader’s gaze shifted to my two empty hands.

“Without even a weapon?”

“For the likes of you, my fists are enough.”

“Looks like the Young Master learned a move or two somewhere… But aren’t you taking Murim a little too lightly?”

“Murim isn’t a joke. You are.”

The moment I stepped toward the brightly burning torch, the prisoners who had been quietly restrained began screaming.

“Wh-what?”

“Boss! Boss!”

“Have you bastards lost your minds? Shut your mouths!”

The men in the rear drew daggers and held them to the prisoners’ throats in response to their violent reaction. The leader stared at me with wary eyes.

“You know them?”

“No. Never seen them before in my life.”

Their reaction was so sudden that even I was caught off guard. And why were they calling me Boss?

“Bosss! It’s me! It’s us!”

“These men seem to know you.”

“They’re just asking me to save them… Huh?”

I looked closely at the prisoners. They were all short as children and had uniformly ugly faces. They looked vaguely familiar.

Is it because they're built like goblins?

Wait. Goblins?

A distant memory suddenly surfaced. No, it wasn't even that distant. It had happened only a few months earlier, during the tutorial Quest.

"Don't tell me… You were with the Heavenly Axe?"

The prisoners—or rather, the Five-Colored Ghosts, former subordinates of Jang Sam the Heavenly Axe—nodded frantically.

"That's us!"

"Boss! Please save us!"

I never expected to run into these bastards here. While I stood dumbfounded, Wolhwa, who had been watching from behind, asked,

"Are they acquaintances of yours, Young Master Jin?"

"We've met before, at least."

Human traffickers and bandits. It was hard to say which was worse.

A moment ago, I'd been planning to save them. Now I was having second thoughts.

"Bosssss!"

"Are you going to abandon us?"

"We quit being bandits after that day and have lived good lives ever since!"

"…"

Their ability to read the situation was almost supernatural. No wonder. They had surrendered immediately when the Heavenly Axe died, after all.

"Are you going to save them?"

"Tsk. I think we have to, at least."

They said they had turned over a new leaf after that day, and leaving them like this wouldn't sit right with me. More importantly, former bandits were far better than active human traffickers.

The leader overheard us and cut in with a growl.

"Save them? You?"

"You heard the whole thing. Why ask again? You sure know how to make life difficult for yourself."

"You little shit. I've let you run your mouth long enough…"

Clang!

The leader leveled his spear at me, and his men drew their weapons as well. Wolhwa clung to my side with a deliberately frightened expression.

"Oh my, I'm scared. You have to protect me, don't you?"

Her moist eyes stirred a man's protective instinct. Her expression was pleading.

Knowing Wolhwa's true nature, I found the sight ridiculous. The men, however, swallowed hard.

“Now I have one more reason to kill you.”

When the leader gave her a lecherous look, Wolhwa shrieked.

“Oh no, oh no! This maiden is so scared!”

“Ho ho, don’t be so frightened. Though I may have lived a rough life, you’ll soon learn that I’m a man with a heart as soft as silk. In a little while, we can have a conversation with our bodies.”

“Hey, look at me first.”

I needed to tear that filthy mouth open so he’d never say anything like that again.

I strode toward him, then abruptly stopped. The leader saw me halt and burst into laughter.

“What’s wrong? Lost your nerve now that it’s time to fight? Too late.”

“Exactly. You’re in real trouble now.”

“…What?”

I gave the bewildered man a broad smile.

“I said you’re fucked, asshole.”

The moment I finished speaking, the ground shook, and a powerful wind whipped through the area.

Boom—whoosh!

It all happened in the blink of an eye.

Something swept past Wolhwa and me at terrifying speed and was already standing in front of the leader.

“Say that again.”

Jin Mukyung.

An overwhelming wave of qi poured from his entire body and crushed the entire scene. The leader’s face turned deathly pale, and his hands began to tremble.

“F-forgive me. Please…”

A cold voice answered.

“You’re far too late.”

Perhaps Jin Mukyung was the greatest pacifist among us. In just over ten seconds, he had put an end to all the unnecessary fighting that would have followed.

“S-surrender! We surrender!”

“Please spare us! Please, just let us live…”

Their faces were frozen with terror. Everyone’s legs gave out, and they collapsed where they stood. Someone’s urine trickled down the hill.

The Five-Colored Ghosts were no different.

“Quiet.”

Jin Mukyung wiped the blood from his face and tossed out that single word. A deathly silence fell.

Hyuk Mujin, one eye bruised deep blue, whispered to me,

“Am I actually alive right now?”

“Yeah. Your breath against my ear is giving me goose bumps, so move away.”

“Just a moment ago, I was wondering how anyone could get beaten like a dog that badly, but now…”

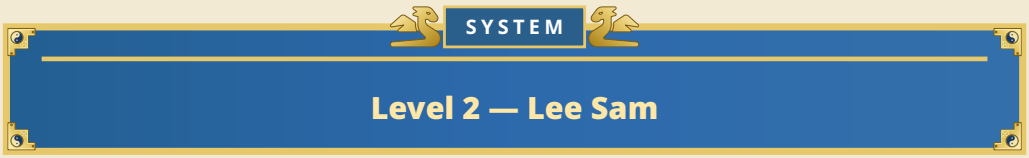
Gulp.

Hyuk Mujin swallowed dryly, his gaze fixed on the fallen leader.

“Hng… Hng…”

With all four limbs broken and his dantian destroyed, the man struggled for breath. If he received proper care, he might be able to walk again, but his life as a martial artist was over.

The Level window I sensed through Qi Sense was proof.



The dung flies those watchers used as Familiars were Level 1, if I remember right.

The culprit who had reduced a Level 25 martial artist—one who had once been close to First Rate—to a living corpse kept stealing glances in our direction.

“Captain, please save me. I think the Second Young Master is still short on blood.”

“Stop talking nonsense and move that guy somewhere suitable. He’ll die if you leave him like that.”

“Doesn’t he deserve to die? They were selling perfectly innocent commoners.”

“Move him anyway. He’s still alive.”

One of the greatest sources of dissonance I had felt while moving between Murim and the modern world was the issue of killing people.

For twenty-seven years, I had lived in a society governed by law and order.

I had trained to kill enemies with bladed weapons, but my targets had been monsters, not living humans.

I was sure that was the case…

Now I couldn’t even remember how many people I had killed. Even after realizing that the enemies who had died by my hand might have been real people rather than NPCs, I hadn’t felt much guilt.

They were enemies. They were trying to kill me too.

I didn’t know whether it was because I had lived as a Hunter or because I had grown accustomed to Murim’s ways. I was only surprised by my own numbness and the simplicity of my self-justification.

For now, this much should be fine.

I was living in two completely different worlds. I couldn't afford to play at being some half-baked Buddhist disciple.

I shook off the thoughts clinging to me and approached the men cowering on the ground.

"Eek!"

"Uaaagh! Save me, Boss!"

"You bastards make a fuss even when I'm trying to save you. Hold still."

I untied the ropes, and the Five-Colored Ghosts were free. They stood on trembling legs.

"Th-thank you."

"We'll serve you as our Benefactor for the rest of our lives!"

"Like hell you will. Anyway, how did you end up getting caught by men like these? All five of you at once?"

The Five-Colored Ghosts were small, but they were grown men, at least in name. They had been strong enough to commit banditry alongside the Heavenly Axe.

"Um, well…"

"…?"

What was wrong with these guys?

Sensing something off in their hesitation, I grabbed the nearest human trafficker by the collar and hauled him up.

"How did you catch them?"

"We caught them trying to steal our money pouches in the marketplace."

"…"

What the hell, these Ten-Colored Ghosts.[690] I thought they had quit being bandits and might have taken up farming, but they had only changed occupations?

"Explain yourselves."

Under my piercing stare, the five men's eyes darted around.

"W-well…"

"Boss, this is the only kind of thing people like us ever learned to do."

"E-even so, we only started recently!"

"We tried to work honestly, but nothing went right… We said we'd pull just one job and get out, but then…"

"If we'd known they were mounted bandits, we never would've touched them. We're victims too. Boss, please forgive us just this once!"

As I wondered what to do with these men, a familiar word made me pause.

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[690] *Sip-saek-gwi* ("Ten-Colored Ghosts") plays on the group's Five-Colored Ghosts nickname and sounds like a Korean insult.

“What did you say?”

“We’ll live honestly if you forgive us just one more time!”

“No, not that. What did they say?”

“Ah, do you mean the mounted-bandit group?”

“Yeah. That.”

“We only found out after they caught us. Some ruffians were throwing silver nyang[691] around at a pleasure house, so we followed them… Turns out they were from the Red Wind Band, infamous for their viciousness even among mounted bandits.”

“The Red Wind Band? Are you sure?”

“Yes. I heard it clearly with my own ears. Right?”

The others began eagerly adding their own pieces.

“They also said they were leaving at first light tomorrow.”

“They said they’d have to ride without stopping to reach Saneum. They were even worried they might lose their heads if they arrived late.”

“So that’s how it is.”

Yesterday, and now today.

Running into mounted bandits from the Red Wind Band two days in a row was already an uncanny coincidence. On top of that, Saneum was close to Eung-hyeon, where the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s headquarters stood.

“Are these men telling the truth?”

The human trafficker whose collar I held in my right hand—or rather, the mounted bandit from the Red Wind Band—nodded, trembling.

At that moment—

Shriek!

A hawk landed in front of the shrine with a sharp cry. A small cylinder tied to its ankle caught my eye.

A messenger eagle.

Things were taking a strange turn.

[691] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not modern Korean won.

Chapter 109

A messenger eagle.

I'd heard that even the Jin Family of Taiyuan had only two of these birds. They were so difficult to train that they were used only to deliver important information…

Who sent it?

Just as I was about to approach the messenger eagle, Wolhwa's voice stopped me.

"You'd better keep your distance. It's extremely wary. If you try to catch it, Young Master Jin, it'll fly away."

"Ah, could it be?"

"It's a messenger eagle from our sect. It's trained to follow a specific tracking scent."

Wolhwa pulled a small pouch from her robes and shook it. The messenger eagle cautiously approached and rubbed its beak against the pouch.

While it was distracted, a Lower District Sect member who had already slipped outside untied the cylinder bound to its ankle.

"Where's it from?"

"It was sent to you from the Sakju Branch yesterday, Branch Leader."

"Give it to me."

Wolhwa accepted the letter and read it, her expression turning inscrutable.

After a moment, her tightly pressed lips parted.

"The Red Wind Band Leader… He's more than I expected."

"Is this about the Red Wind Band again?"

Wolhwa nodded slightly and handed me the letter.

She wanted me to read it, so there was no reason to refuse. Jin Mukyung and Hyuk Mujin, who had been hanging back, cautiously leaned in as well.

> The Red Wind Band is heading south across Gaoyuan. Their numbers are estimated at approximately two hundred.

The meaning of that single terse line was clear.

"They're planning to attack the Mount Heng Sword Sect again."

"There's no doubt about it. This news is already a day old, so they must have closed the distance by at least that much, if not more."

We were currently a day and a half away from the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

As mounted bandits, they would be advancing on their destination at remarkable speed.

“Unfortunately, our branch doesn’t have a proper intelligence network in the north. The one fortunate thing is…”

Wolhwa’s gaze shifted toward the Red Wind Band’s mounted bandits. They had lost the will to fight long ago, and they flinched and lowered their heads.

“We have some valuable sources of information right here. Whether they know anything useful is another matter.”

She looked over the mounted bandits, then abruptly pointed at one of them.

“You. Stand up.”

“…M-me?”

The terrified young man rose. He was younger than I had expected. The youngest and weakest of the mounted bandits, he couldn’t even meet Wolhwa’s eyes.

“How old are you?”

“I-I turned twenty this year.”

“Twenty? You’re young. Then again, being young doesn’t stop someone from becoming a mounted bandit.”

“I’m not a mounted bandit! I only became a wandering martial artist recently, but then they said they’d give me a big cut, so I…”

“Ah, so you’re one of the wandering martial artists the Red Wind Band Leader gathered for the last attack?”

“Y-yes! I’ll tell you everything I know!”

“No, it’s all right.”

“Pardon?”

“You don’t look like you know much anyway. What would be the point? Isn’t that right, Chunsam?”

The Lower District Sect member who had silently played the part of our carriage driver until now.

Instead of answering, he pulled a small knife from his robes and drove it into the young man’s chest.

Thunk—

The swift, precise One Strike of a First Rate martial artist split his heart. The young man’s mouth opened and closed soundlessly before he collapsed like a puppet with its strings cut.

Thud.

A frigid silence pressed down on the scene. While the mounted bandits stared in horror and fear, Wolhwa’s slender finger moved once more.

“You.”

“I-I’ll talk! I’ll tell you everything! I’ve been with the Red Wind Band for a year…”

“Chunsam.”

Whoosh! Slash!

“Grrk… Gurg…”

The mounted bandit staggered backward, making a wet, blood-choked sound. He tried to cover his gaping throat, but couldn’t stop the fountain of blood spraying between his fingers.

“You only need to remember two things.”

Covered from head to toe in bright-red blood, Wolhwa continued in a dry voice.

“Answer only what you’re asked, and tell the truth exactly as it is.”

“…!”

In mere moments, we learned everything there was to know about the Red Wind Band.

Once we realized there wasn’t a moment to lose, we abandoned the carriage and each chose a horse—me, Jin Mukyung, Hyuk Mujin, and Wolhwa.

Chunsam would take the Five-Colored Ghosts and the surviving mounted bandits to the nearest Lower District Sect branch and report the situation.

“Was that too cruel?”

Wolhwa asked as she saddled her horse. I scratched my chin.

“To be honest, I was a little surprised.”

I’d only ever seen her relaxed and playful, so I had briefly forgotten that she was a martial artist too.

And an experienced one at that.

How old was Wolhwa, anyway?

I’d never asked, so I couldn’t be sure, but she couldn’t have been over thirty.

Becoming the Branch Leader in charge of all Shanxi Province at such a young age meant she possessed the decisiveness the position demanded.

Cruel, but effective.

She had killed two people without hesitation. Just as casually as swatting flies.

Jin Mukyung’s display against the leader must have terrified the mounted bandits, but the fear of death was even greater.

Driven to the edge of a cliff, they had no choice but to pour out information desperately.

“I think I would’ve spilled everything too.”

“I’m saying this in case Young Master Jin gets the wrong idea, but I don’t enjoy killing people. They weren’t innocent commoners, either… Ah, this bastard’s blood just won’t stop, even when I wipe it.”

The blood streaming down her belonged to the second mounted bandit.

As she wrinkled her nose, someone held out a piece of cloth.

"U-use this to wipe it off."

"Oh my."

"Huh?"

"Hmm."

At the reactions from Wolhwa, me, and Hyuk Mujin, Jin Mukyung cleared his throat repeatedly.

"I thought you might need it."

"Thank you, Young Hero Jin. This is exactly what I needed."

"It's nothing."

He said that, but he looked awfully pleased with himself.

No way. Is he…

The type who's only nice to women?

There was always at least one guy like that wherever you went. Even the Heaven Shaking Sword wasn't any different, apparently.

After wiping away the blood, Wolhwa pulled a rolled-up piece of leather from her robes and spread it out.

"This is a rough map covering all of Shanxi Province. We're here. The Red Wind Band has probably… If they've been moving without rest, they may already have broken through Datong."

"They're faster than us."

"By half a day, for now. But the official roads along our route are well maintained. If we ride day and night, we should be able to close the gap."

In short, we shouldn't expect any rest.

I followed the others and vaulted into the saddle.

Why does trouble always break out the moment I arrive?

I sighed inwardly, but what could I do? This wasn't my first hardship—or my second. By now I just had to accept it.

Wasn't this supposed to be a really simple Quest?

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest difficulty has changed to Peak.

"…"

Right. Not anymore, I guess.

He was a man who resembled a fox. His pointed chin and ears, along with his sharp, slanted eyes, watched and observed everything around him at once.

“Graaah!”

“Kill them! Kill every last one of them!”

“Aaaah!”

Smoke billowed from a large manor, accompanied by screams.

Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader, sat astride his horse atop a hill and watched the scene below. He didn’t speak until the manor had fallen silent.

“Is it over?”

A mounted bandit who had just come up the hill to report answered him.

“We killed all the men and gathered the women and children together.”

“Why?”

“Pardon? Why, it’s the tradition of Gaoyuan…”

Any male taller than a cartwheel—even a child—was killed without mercy, while the women were taken or sold as slaves. It was a tradition—or something close to one—passed down from the nomads.

At the mounted bandit’s words, Pung Yang quietly crooked one finger.

“Come closer.”

The mounted bandit approached hesitantly and asked carefully,

“Leader, did I perhaps make some serious mistake…”

“Who were you with before?”

“Until recently, I was the deputy captain of the Earth Tiger Band.”

“The Earth Tiger Band? Ah, I remember. You were their deputy captain.”

“Y-yes! I was so impressed by your formidable martial arts and noble character that I swore to become your loyal subordinate!”

Pung Yang scratched his nose with an ambiguous expression.

Was that so?

All he remembered was killing a piece of trash in a single strike—the man who had swaggered around calling himself a bandit leader while commanding some thirty subordinates.

“My memory differs a little, but thank you anyway.”

“Not at all! It’s an honor!”

“Still, whatever the Earth Tiger Band may have been like, things are different in the Red Wind Band. Petty matters like the traditions of Gaoyuan, for instance.”

“Ah, I didn’t realize.”

“My orders as leader take priority. Do you understand?”

“I’ll keep that in mind—over and over again!”

“Those fellows probably followed Gaoyuan’s traditions because they didn’t know any better. They all joined recently, just like you. Would you go and tell them what I want?”

“Your command is my law. I won’t leave a single one alive.”

The mounted bandit even gave an awkward military salute, though there was nothing military about a mounted bandit. Pung Yang waved him away.

“Yes, go on.”

“Yes, Leader!”

Pung Yang watched him ride away, then suddenly flicked his sleeve.

Whoosh!

A streak of light split the air and pierced its target ten jang[692]—about thirty meters—away.

Thnk! Thud.

The horse kept galloping.

It had no idea that its rider was already dead, his foot caught in the stirrup and his body being battered to pieces against the ground.

“Go and tell them. There are no prisoners. Kill them all and burn the place.”

“Yes, Leader.”

Not long after Pung Yang’s subordinate departed, the entire manor was engulfed in flames. As he watched the signboard burn away in an instant, a faint smile touched the corners of his mouth.

Mount Heng Sword Sect, Datong Branch.

It was the moment the Red Wind Band crossed Gaoyuan once more.

The messenger’s report left the people arguing in the spacious main hall breathless.

“They’ve broken through Datong!”

“A-already?”

“What about the Datong Branch? What happened to the men who went out to stand guard?”

“Wiped out. They were all wiped out. The Datong Branch was reduced to ashes, and there wasn’t a single survivor.”

“What?”

“Could the report be wrong? They must have suffered heavy losses last time, so how could they have come this far so quickly…?”

[692] Jang is a traditional unit of length. Ten jang is approximately 30.3 meters, or 99 ft.

“They appear to have absorbed another mounted-bandit group. At least two hundred men—possibly more.”

“Is that certain?”

“Yes, without a doubt.”

“Th-then when will they reach us…?”

“If they’re fast, the attack will begin within a day. At the latest, we expect it within two days.”

“We’re finished.”

The muttered words were not much different from what most of the people gathered there were thinking.

There were around ten of them, all senior figures holding important positions in the Mount Heng Sword Sect. Yet every one of them was already turning the word *defeat* over in their minds.

“Iron Sword Squad Leader, are you confident in this fight?”

“Why are you asking me, when you’re a Pavilion Leader? Am I the only martial artist here?”

They were squad leaders, hall leaders, and pavilion leaders of the great Mount Heng Sword Sect.

There had been a time when he had desperately wanted to rise to that position. Once upon a time, that was.

To hell with the great Mount Heng Sword Sect. What good is a promotion now, with the sect in this state?

We were already on the verge of collapse, and now a mounted-bandit group has come to raise hell. Let’s see… If we scrape together everyone we have left, we might reach a hundred.

The war with the Jin Family of Taiyuan had cost them nearly eighty percent of their strength.

They had lost the elite martial artists they had painstakingly trained and the seasoned senior figures who had weathered countless trials in the martial world. Most painful of all was the loss of the Peak masters who embodied the sect’s power—and of its financial resources.

“Damn it. If only the Sect Leader were still alive.”

Lee Cheonbaek had started as a mere wandering martial artist and built the Mount Heng Sword Sect into what it was now. With his martial arts and resourcefulness, he could have turned this situation around.

But the Blood Wolf Sword, Lee Cheonbaek, was already dead. Of his bloodline, only one person remained alive.

“To think we have to serve some little girl who isn’t even twenty as Sect Leader at a time like this.”

The moment someone spat out those words in anger—

Boom!

The tightly closed doors of the main hall exploded.

Chapter 110

Boom!

The thunderous crash heralded the arrival of a powerfully built middle-aged man.

Beneath his thick, bristling brows, he swept the hall with tiger eyes like an enraged beast.

“Which one of you was spouting that nonsense just now?”

Everyone gathered here was a senior figure of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Even if they weren’t on their predecessor’s level, they possessed First Rate martial arts and considerable experience. Yet even they were busy shrinking back and avoiding his gaze.

The middle-aged man before them had every right to make them do so.

Damn it. Of all people, it had to be the Tiger of Mount Heng…

The storytellers said that two beasts lived on Mount Heng.

The Blood Wolf Sword and the Tiger of Mount Heng. The closest of friends, yet each a wall the other had to overcome.

The middle-aged man, Cheol Mubaek, had been a Peak master known as the tiger of Mount Heng for decades.

“I asked which one of you it was!”

His roar made every hair on the senior figures’ bodies stand on end.

They said that whenever Cheol Mubaek lost his temper, even his close friend Lee Cheonbaek would leave the area. These men lagged far behind him in both martial arts and age. What more needed to be said?

“We should be united in driving out those mounted-bandit bastards, and even that would not be enough, yet you dare defy Cheonbaek’s dying wishes and harbor rebellious intentions?”

Under his gaze, which seemed ready to pour out flames, the senior figures of the Mount Heng Sword Sect flinched as though they had been burned.

“G-Great Hero Cheol, you misunderstand.”

“How could we ever dare harbor rebellious intentions?”

“Then have I grown so old that my ears no longer work?”

At that moment, everyone inside the main hall felt thirsty. It wasn’t a simple illusion. It was caused by the terrifying Scorching Yang Qi radiating from Cheol Mubaek.

This is insane.

What the hell did he eat to amass such monstrous internal energy…?

Just being near him made it hard to breathe, and sweat poured down their bodies. The Tiger of Mount Heng. This was the moment the true nature of the Peak master

who had supposedly trained alone somewhere in the vast mountain range since around the age of twenty revealed itself.

“Huff… Haaah…”

“Great Hero, please calm yourself… Hah.”

The senior figures of the Mount Heng Sword Sect panted harshly, while the Peak master glared at them without the slightest sign of forgiveness.

Just as the air in the hall threatened to boil like lava—

“Uncle Cheol, it’s hot.”

A voice as clear and refreshing as a stream, and slender white fingers tugging at Cheol Mubaek’s sleeve. At the same time, the angry furrows in his brow smoothed out as though someone had pulled them flat.

“W-Was it very hot?”

“Yes. I can’t even breathe.”

“Oh dear. I didn’t think of you. How is it now?”

“Much better. Thank you, Uncle Cheol.”

“Don’t say such things. Protecting you, Seowol, is my duty.”

Cheol Mubaek’s mighty Scorching Yang Qi subsided.

Only then did held breaths burst out across the hall. Once the people soaked in sweat came to their senses, they realized that Cheol Mubaek was not alone.

“Y-Young Lady.”

“We greet the Young Lady.”

Cheol Mubaek raised his brows at the senior figures hurriedly standing to show their respect. But the “Young Lady” was faster.

“I’ll tell you both one last time, Iron Sword Squad Leader, Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion.”

The woman who had been hidden behind Cheol Mubaek’s massive frame stepped into view. She was slim and graceful, and the hem of her blue gown rustled whenever it brushed the floor.

“Change how you address me. Not Young Lady—Sect Leader.”

Those who met her frost-covered gaze remembered one fact they had momentarily forgotten.

Ah. That’s right.

The Blood Wolf Sword, Lee Cheonbaek.

Lee Seowol was the child in whom his blood ran strongest.

I knew nothing about horseback riding. After coming to Murim, I had ridden only a few times. In the modern world, horseback riding was practically an aristocratic sport reserved for the rich, so I'd never had the chance to try it.

But perhaps because my physical abilities were so good and I was riding a well-trained horse, I had enough leisure to look at the System Window even during a furious gallop.

Open Quest Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest

Yesterday's Enemy, Today's Ally

Now that all the truth has been revealed, the Mount Heng Sword Sect is not an enemy but an ally you must join hands with. Invite them to the Jin Family of Taiyuan during the upcoming New Year's Day.

Grade: Peak

Restriction: Jin Taekyung

Objective: Deliver the invitation (Incomplete)

Reward: ???

Failure: None

Quests were fluid. Depending on the circumstances, sudden Quests could appear or existing Quests could be updated, as this one had been.

The Grade was raised.

The Quest Grade changing from First Rate to Peak meant that the road to the Mount Heng Sword Sect had become anything but easy.

For example, the Red Wind Band. Or the Red Wind Band. Probably the Red Wind Band…

Never mind. Thinking about it any more would only hurt.

Every day in this place is like walking on thin ice.

I thought I'd finally received an easy Quest for once, only for trouble to erupt again.

The reason I wasn't as anxious as before was partly because of the reliable presence of Jin Mukyung, but also because I myself had grown stronger.

Open Status Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Level: 55 — Jin Taekyung
Class: First Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 1,300 (+150)
Titles: 4 (Title effects active)
— Returnee (All stats +10)
— Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi (All stats +10, Fame +100)
— Scion of a Prestigious Family (All stats +5, Fame +50)
— Gambler (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one combat)
Strength: 196 (+25)
Stamina: 195 (+25)
Agility: 192 (+25)
Intelligence: 35 (+25)
Charm: 35 (+25)
Internal Energy: 15 years
Toughness: 155 (+25)
Remaining Points: 0

Ahh, barkeep.

Look how well I've grown. All by myself.

Strength, Agility, and Stamina were each nearing 200. Just looking at them made me feel full, and my Toughness, born from getting beaten by Jin Mukyung, was growing nicely too.

The Title bonuses are hefty, too. This should be enough.

Until now, I had raised my stats just to survive. Every time I advanced a Quest, one crisis after another came crashing down like three waves at once. There was no way I could afford to invest points in Charm or Intelligence.

Even if I raised my Intelligence enough to reach an IQ of 180, it's not like I'd start thrusting a spear scientifically.

The same went for Charm. Jopil and the Head Elder weren't going to spare me just because I was handsome.

Of course, raising them would help me in some way eventually. But with my life hanging by a thread, I hadn't had the courage to invest in noncombat stats.

I can protect this one life of mine to some extent now.

Once this Quest was over, I planned to devote some attention to my internal energy and noncombat stats.

As it was, the items I had obtained after defeating Jopil—including the Blazing Flame Divine Pill—were sitting untouched in my Inventory.

Of course, taking it wrong could send me straight to the grave.

Just then, Wolhwa, who had been riding at the front, spotted a stream and pulled to a stop.

“We’ll rest for a little while. The horses are too exhausted.”

How much time had passed?

We had ridden without stopping since leaving the shrine. Dawn had broken, and now the sun hung high overhead. System messages announcing increases to my Strength and Stamina had even appeared twice, so this really had been a forced march.

“Whew. My ass is killing me. If I’d known this would happen, I should’ve been born the son of a coachman instead of a farmer.”

While the horses rested, Hyuk Mujin dropped heavily to the ground. Since he was the lowest-level member of the group, his exhaustion was obvious.

“Having a hard time?”

Hyuk Mujin wiped the sweat from his forehead with his sleeve before answering.

“Honestly, yes… But strangely enough, it’s much better than last time.”

“Last time?”

“You’ve already forgotten? During the scouting mission.”

“Ah, I remember.”

I had nearly died after running into Jopil during a scouting mission for White Tiger Hall. We had taken horses with us then too.

Though we ended up abandoning them when the heavy snow came.

The memory drew a quiet laugh from me.

“What’s wrong?”

“I was thinking about you. You mouthed off to me without knowing any better and got the crap beaten out of you.”

“…Do you really have to dredge up the past to feel better?”

“You’re the one who asked, punk.”

“Anyway, I’m saying it seems much better than back then.”

“Really?”

“Yes. We’ve ridden much farther than we did during the scouting mission, but I’m not even that tired. Maybe I’m getting used to riding?”

“Maybe… Ah, wait.”

“Hm?”

Something suddenly occurred to me, so I heightened my Qi Sense.

Ding.

With the familiar System notification, a Level Window appeared over Hyuk Mujin’s bewildered face.

SYSTEM

Level: 38 — Hyuk Mujin

"…Huh?"

A breathy sound escaped my open mouth. When had Hyuk Mujin's Level gotten this high?

Strictly speaking, it wasn't all that high.

But considering that he had been only Level 20 when we first met, calling it astonishing progress wasn't enough. At this point, it was practically like he had been reborn.

Come to think of it, his Level has been rising steadily ever since we met.

As I searched my memory, the details came back more clearly.

It had been the same when we reunited as a scouting unit. Whenever I heightened my Qi Sense from time to time, Hyuk Mujin's Level had risen by one or two.

Now he was Level 38. In terms of time spent in Murim, he had nearly doubled his Level in just over two months.

Then maybe…?

With a doubtful heart, I stared intently at Hyuk Mujin.

What if he received stat points like I did? Could I distribute them for him?

It's possible.

Judging by how much stronger I was than a Hunter or martial artist of a similar Level, there seemed to be some kind of System enhancement effect…

It's worth trying once.

"Why are you staring at me like that? Is there something on my face?"

"No. You're just ugly."

"…Seriously."

I grabbed Hyuk Mujin by the shoulder and shouted inwardly.

Open Status Window!

At that very moment—

"What are you doing? My shoulder hurts."

"Oh. Okay."

Nothing happened. I thought at least something would appear.

Then again, my main character was still far from reaching the Level cap. Why would my alt character get anything? Still, it was disappointing.

Should I try saying it out loud?

They would definitely treat me like some kind of weirdo, but it was better than moving on with the feeling of not washing my hands after using the bathroom.

I stealthily placed my hand against Hyuk Mujin's back—lightly, very lightly—and muttered under my breath.

"Open Status Window."

"Seriously, what has gotten into you today?"

I ignored him and shot to my feet.

The notification I had been waiting for chimed, and a System Window appeared.

"Yes! There it is!"

Ding.

SYSTEM

The Quest condition Time Limit has been added.
Arrive at the Mount Heng Sword Sect within 22:00:00. If you are late, there will be no turning back.

"Yes…"

My voice died away. My eyes trembled.

A time limit? What the hell kind of time limit is this?

Why are you doing this to me? Seriously.

As I let out a deep sigh, Wolhwa's eyes widened and she asked,

"Young Master Jin, are you hurt?"

"No, it's not that. Do you know around when we'll arrive?"

"Hmm. At today's pace, before tomorrow evening?"

"Ah."

It was a little past noon now. That meant we still had more than a full day's ride ahead of us.

Judging by the Quest Window's change, it seemed the Red Wind Band bastards would attack the Mount Heng Sword Sect within that time limit…

What was I supposed to do?

"Shall we get going soon?"

"The horses are tired. They need to rest for half a shichen.[693]"

"Horses, you're fine, aren't you? You heard that, right? They said they're fine."

"…"

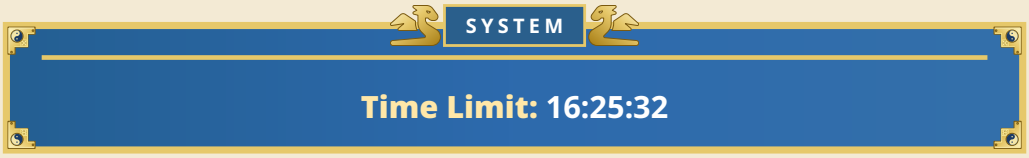
Yeah. I knew you'd look at me like that.

[693] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Chapter 111

Thudthudthudthud!

Four fine horses thundered down the main road. Exhausted from too little rest, they were already gasping for breath, but we couldn't afford to ease the reins.



31, 30. The time kept ticking down.

Three *shichen*—a full six hours—had already passed. We had stopped at a small village along the way to look for fresh horses, but all they had were small, painfully slow packhorses.

We really do need to rest.

We were trapped between a rock and a hard place.

We had been forcing our march as hard as we could, but the time limit was dangerously close. If we kept running like this, the horses wouldn't hold out.

Do we have a choice?

I was just about to suggest to Wolhwa and Jin Mukyung that we rest, even if only briefly, when—

"Hm?"

"Young Master Jin! Ahead!"

Even without Wolhwa's shout, I had already seen them. Several dozen *jang*[694] ahead, a group of dark figures blocked the main road.

Every one of them wore filthy clothes, with a single curved saber sticking out from his belt. There was no need to say anything more.

The Red Wind Band.

The men had surrounded what appeared to be ordinary civilians and were threatening them. At the sound of hoofbeats, they whipped their heads around.

The mounted bandits spotted me riding well out in front and grinned, baring their yellow teeth.

"Well, look at that. Our next customer's here already. Stop!"

"Oh, sure."

They told me to stop, so I had to stop. What else could I do?

Thud! Thud!

"Gaaah!"

"Argh!"

[694] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

My horse didn’t come to a halt until it had trampled the two or so men blocking the road. The mounted bandits—and even the travelers they had captured—stared at me wide-eyed.

“You—you bastard!”

I hopped down from the saddle and asked,

“I’m asking just to make sure. You’re the Red Wind Band, right?”

“Who the hell are you?”

“Judging by your reaction, I guess I was right. I’m short on time, so let’s finish this quickly.”

Without hesitation, I kicked the nearest man in the leg.

Crack.

With a chilling sound, his shinbone snapped, and he crumpled to the ground.

It all happened in an instant. The others stood stunned for a moment, then hastily leveled their curved sabers and spears at me.

“Kill him!”

“A man should always watch his back.”

“What?”

“I said, watch behind you.”

The instant I finished speaking, ten pairs of eyes turned to look behind them.

Craack! Thud!

Three fine horses charging at full speed swept the men away.

The battle was over before it had even begun. The men struck by the horses had been sent flying like bowling pins and lay sprawled out half-dead. The rest were easily subdued.

“P-Please, just spare my life.”

“I won’t kill you. But I’ll have to fix a few things first.”

“Eek!”

While Jin Mukyung methodically broke the limbs of the surviving bandits, Hyuk Mujin brought over the horses tied up beside the road.

“It looks like we can switch to these healthy ones. There must be at least ten of them, so we might as well take them all and change horses whenever one gets tired.”

I had been thinking the same thing. Unlike the last group we encountered, these mounted bandits each had their own horses. It was fortunate.

But still…

How many of these Red Wind Band bastards were there?

According to the information we obtained at the shrine, more than a hundred remnants had scattered throughout northern Shanxi.

Some were hiding in the foothills, while others were concealed in remote villages or crowded areas, gathering at a designated rendezvous point when ordered.

These men aren't stragglers.

They were ambush forces carrying out an operation. The Red Wind Band Leader was replenishing his forces on the plateau and moving south, while sending the subordinates he had left behind north.

I could easily understand why Wolhwa had described the Red Wind Band Leader as such a terrifying man.

The judgment to retreat swiftly when the tide turned against him. The meticulousness to prepare his next plan even while retreating. And the drive to put that plan into action.

On top of that, I had heard that his own martial arts were formidable.

At this point, I almost felt bad for treating him as nothing more than a mounted bandit.

This has gotten seriously messy.

Now I understood why the Quest Grade had risen to Peak. Things kept getting worse the more I learned.

Surely the Red Wind Band Leader wasn't a Peak master too… right?

I asked Wolhwa just in case, and she immediately nodded.

"Yes. He is."

"…Ah."

"There has to be a reason someone rose to prominence so quickly. He isn't widely known yet, but according to our sect's intelligence, the Red Wind Band Leader is indeed a Peak master."

I was dumbfounded.

"Why would a Peak master become a mounted bandit?"

"There are even Supreme Peak masters among mountain bandits and water bandits. Why couldn't a mounted bandit be one?"

"Supreme Peak masters? Among mountain bandits and water bandits?"

"If you ever meet the Green Forest Alliance Leader or the Alliance Leader of the Yangtze River Channel League, ask them yourself. Not that you ever will."

"…I sincerely hope that's true."

A Supreme Peak master? I genuinely hoped I would never meet one.

I shook my head repeatedly and mounted one of the newly taken horses. Jin Mukyung and Hyuk Mujin followed after tying up the Red Wind Band's mounted bandits and handing them over to the commoners.

SYSTEM

Time Limit: 15:59:13

The time limit continued to tick down even now. Leaving the commoners behind as they bowed deeply in thanks, we kicked the horses in the ribs.

“Giddyap!”

Deep within the inner grounds of the Mount Heng Sword Sect stood a garden that only a very small number of people were allowed to enter. Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng, was the only outsider granted that privilege.

“This is my first time here.”

“Because it was a special place. Whenever Father had something weighing on his mind, he would come to the garden.”

Lee Seowol walked through the snow-covered garden, her footsteps crunching softly. Then she suddenly stopped when she spotted a frost-covered flower.

“Mother loved this flower.”

“Did she?”

“Yes. Whenever she tended the garden, she would always bring me here and tell me the names of the flowers.”

After thinking quietly for a moment, Lee Seowol continued.

“But I can’t remember it now.”

“It was a long time ago. Don’t trouble yourself over it.”

“Uncle Cheol.”

“Yes?”

“I don’t like flowers. I only followed Mother because she liked them. In truth, I never cared about flowers. It’s the same reason Father used to come to the garden.”

Lee Seowol slowly looked around the snow-covered garden. The flowers had withered, and the number of burial mounds in the center of the garden had grown from one to four.

Her gaze sank as she silently stared at the mounds where her family slept.

Whose fault was it?

Perhaps it was her own fault for being born the daughter of a Murim martial artist.

That was why she had lost her father and two older brothers one after another, after losing her mother ten years ago.

I should have kept trying to stop him until the very end…

A memory from two months ago suddenly resurfaced and blurred her vision.

It had been a conversation between father and daughter, held late one night with no one else present.

“I’ll have to tie you to the third son of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“The third son? Surely you’re not thinking of marrying me to that good-for-nothing?”

“No. But it will become an unbearable scandal for you.”

“I see.”

“Is that all you have to say?”

“What can I do? It’s my fault for having a heartless father.”

“You’re a child I can never understand. Are you really all right with this?”

“If I say I don’t like it, will you change your mind?”

“At the very least, I’ll look for another way.”

“So the war with the Jin Family of Taiyuan is a foregone conclusion.”

“Now that the Strange Hero of Shanxi and the Heaven Shaking Sword are absent, this is the perfect time. This opportunity will never come again.”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan is strong even without the Family Head and the Second Young Master. Please reconsider.”

“No. My decision has already been made.”

“Then make sure you win. Become strong enough that no one in Shanxi can even open their mouth about a scandal involving me.”

“…If you had been a man, I would have made you the Young Sect Leader.”

“I’m glad I was born a woman. I have no interest in being this sect’s Young Sect Leader.”

Her fears soon became reality.

Had even a fortnight passed before Lee Seogeun returned as a cold corpse? Not long after, she lost Lee Cheonbaek. In the end, even her eldest brother, Lee Seogwang, was gone.

Now I’m alone.

And so, the Blood Wolf Sword Lee Cheonbaek’s last surviving blood relative became the new Sect Leader.

As she silently gazed at the burial mounds, a warm palm gently caressed her shoulder.

“I’m sorry. I should have come sooner…”

“Uncle Cheol, please don’t say that. If you hadn’t come, our sect wouldn’t have been able to hold out this long.”

Under the Red Wind Band’s fierce assault, the Mount Heng Sword Sect had been helplessly driven back. If not for the Peak master known as the Tiger of Mount

Heng, who had rushed over after belatedly learning of Lee Cheonbaek's calamity, the enemy would never have withdrawn.

"I'll tear that bastard limb from limb and kill him."

At the thought of the Red Wind Band Leader, Lee Seowol shook her head.

In a life-and-death duel between Peak masters, Cheol Mubaek had the edge.

They had already clashed once, and Pung Yang had retreated with a minor internal injury.

But an opportunity like that will never come again.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had always gathered information on the mounted bandits of northern Gaoyuan and remained constantly on alert.

There were dozens of mounted-bandit groups in Gaoyuan, but among them, the Red Wind Band led by Pung Yang had grown frighteningly fast.

A man particularly strong and meticulous even among Gaoyuan's chieftains.

That man was Pung Yang.

There's no way someone like that would engage Uncle Cheol in a life-and-death duel. If Uncle Cheol rashly tried to confront him, Pung Yang would turn the tables on him instead.

Lee Seowol turned toward Cheol Mubaek.

"Uncle Cheol, could you tell me once more about Pung Yang's martial arts?"

"Early Peak. His saber arts and throwing-knife techniques had reached a high realm. However…"

A deep furrow formed between Cheol Mubaek's brows.

"Every one of his forms was thoroughly insidious. I suspect he has learned demonic, heterodox martial arts."

"Demonic, heterodox arts…"

Ever since the Great Faction War, practicing demonic, heterodox arts had become synonymous with death in the Central Plains. Unorthodox factions might present themselves as orthodox, but no one openly declared themselves unorthodox.

"For now, it's only a suspicion. We'll know if we clash again."

"I trust you, Uncle Cheol. But don't underestimate the Red Wind Band Leader. He has any number of subordinates he can sacrifice in his place."

With enemies bearing down from both directions, their combined force was close to three hundred strong.

Meanwhile, even after gathering every martial artist stationed at its branches, the Mount Heng Sword Sect had less than half that number.

Given the situation, morale was low among both the ordinary martial artists and the newly appointed senior members.

"Seowol. May I say something?"

These were the words of a benefactor who had risked his life out of loyalty to his dead friend. Lee Seowol bowed politely.

“I’ll take your words to heart.”

Cheol Mubaek spoke heavily.

“Leave.”

It was a single word laden with meaning.

But there was not the slightest hesitation in Lee Seowol’s answer.

“I’m sorry.”

“It isn’t too late. You must survive.”

“It isn’t over yet. And I will survive.”

“If you thought Cheonbaek would have wanted this…”

“Uncle.”

At her resolute voice, Cheol Mubaek closed his mouth. Firm determination filled Lee Seowol’s clear eyes.

“This is what I wanted. As the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

“Whew…”

Cheol Mubaek let out a sigh instead of answering.

“I’m already deeply indebted to you, Uncle. Even if you leave now, I won’t resent you.”

“Do you really need to hear my answer before you’ll be satisfied?”

Lee Seowol shook her head. Cheol Mubaek had cherished her like his own child since she was young. In some ways, he had been more of a father to her than her actual father.

“I will never forget this debt. Uncle Cheol, you are the benefactor of both me and the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

“I’ve watched you since you were little, but… you really are a sly child.”

“I was sly when I was young. Now I’m a ruthless bitch.”

Watching Lee Seowol smile faintly, Cheol Mubaek could only continue to sigh deeply.

“Do we have any chance of winning?”

“If we fought now? Ten percent.”

“What?”

“But if reinforcements arrive, fifty percent. More than that.”

“Reinforcements? From the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“A messenger pigeon from the Lower District Sect’s Jeongyang Branch arrived two *shichen* ago.”

“How many are coming? A hundred? Two hundred?”

“Four. One of them is the Heaven Shaking Sword, Jin Mukyung, and another is…”

Lee Seowol let out a wry laugh, reminded of her ill-fated connection with him. “The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung.”

Chapter 112

Mounted bandits riding openly down the main road in broad daylight?

Under normal circumstances, it would be unthinkable. The nearest Murim sect would be the first to act, followed by soldiers from the local authorities.

But if the mounted bandits numbered in the hundreds—enough to overwhelm even the Murim sect responsible for suppressing them—the officials could only close their eyes and cover their ears.

Just like now.

“Ar-aren’t those mounted bandits?”

“Watch what you call them. Do you have three lives or something? That’s the infamous Red Wind Band.”

“The Red Wind Band? Weren’t they defeated by the Mount Heng Sword Sect not long ago?”

“That’s what we thought. But this time seems different. The marketplace is already rife with rumors that the Mount Heng Sword Sect won’t escape total destruction.”

“Still, the sect has some ability. Surely they won’t lose to mere mounted bandits…”

“Hey, watch your mouth! The man riding at the front is Pung Yang, the leader of the Red Wind Band. They say he’s a Peak master.”

“What? A Peak master?”

“Yeah. You can’t dismiss them just because they’re mounted bandits. I hear he isn’t merely strong in martial arts—he’s exceptionally clever, too.”

The commoners’ fearful whispers wormed their way into Pung Yang’s ears and those of his mounted bandits.

A subordinate riding on Pung Yang’s right spoke casually.

“Shall I rip those bastards’ mouths apart?”

“Do you want to?”

“If the Leader permits it, I’ll deal with those two first, then turn the entire village into a sea of flames.”

“You’ll kill the old, capture the young men, and rape the women?”

“Heh heh. Isn’t that what men like us always do? The Mount Heng Sword Sect bastards must be cowering behind their walls by now, scared out of their wits.”

“They probably are. They’ll be gathering all their strength for one final battle.”

“It won’t matter. It’ll be like throwing an egg against a rock. It’s a foregone conclusion that you’ll wipe out the Mount Heng Sword Sect and take its place.”

“That is why I won’t permit it.”

“What?”

Pung Yang burst into hearty laughter at his subordinate’s bewildered reaction.

Every one of them was shortsighted and cruel by nature. That was why they had become mounted bandits—and why Pung Yang kept them close.

Because they're easy to handle.

When his laughter subsided, he spoke.

"Wiping out the Datong Branch was part of the war. But if we harm commoners now, all we'll accomplish is giving the Jin Family of Taiyuan an excuse to intervene."

"Are they the rulers of Shanxi Province or something?"

"Not yet. But they will be soon enough. Before that happens, shouldn't we swallow the Mount Heng Sword Sect and lie flat like dogs?"

"Um, Leader, I'm not doubting you, but… would orthodox factions like the Jin Family of Taiyuan really look favorably on mounted bandits like us?"

"Mounted bandits? Who's a mounted bandit?"

"What?"

"Last time, I noticed that the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect was quite beautiful."

Pung Yang's subordinate blinked several times before finally catching his meaning. The corners of his mouth curled upward.

"She's of marriageable age. I suppose it's time she took a husband."

"She has two choices: total destruction or marriage."

"Then what will happen to the Red Wind Band…?"

"We'll take the heart of it and wear the outer shell. Let's see… Compared to the others, your face is at least presentable. I'll make you Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion."

"Ha ha ha! I'll devote my life to serving you!"

As he listened to his subordinate's laughter, Pung Yang tightened his grip on the reins.

At last, I've made it this far.

He was a cold and levelheaded man, but his heart pounded at the thought that he had taken another step toward his ambition.

Memories from long ago surfaced one after another, flickering before his eyes.

It's already been well over twenty years.

Becoming a mounted bandit had been easier and simpler than he had expected. There were only two ways: go looking for them yourself or get caught by them. In Pung Yang's case, it had been the latter.

When he was young, he had committed a crime and was being taken to the local authorities when a mounted-bandit group attacked. That had been the turning point of his life.

"Boss, there's a kid here too."

“Hm? He’s so scrawny we wouldn’t get more than a few coins for him even if we sold him. Kid, did you get caught pickpocketing?”

“No. I killed someone.”

“You killed someone? How old are you?”

“Thirteen.”

“Why did you kill him?”

“I hadn’t eaten for three days, and the boss had dumplings…”

“Dumplings? Did he take away what you begged for? That would be enough to make anyone snap.”

“No. I was hungry, and I didn’t have the strength to beg. He was eating dumplings right in front of me.”

“…So you killed him?”

“I thought it would be faster to take them and eat them.”

“Hey, let this kid go and feed him something. He’s one of us from today.”

Pung Yang became a mounted bandit that day.

An orphan with no one in the world, he had wandered from place to place begging for food. He was exceptionally perceptive and quick-witted.

Compared to his past, when he had barely eaten a meal every three days, life as a mounted bandit was lavish.

Robbery? Murder?

To Pung Yang, who had committed murder at the age of thirteen simply because he wanted to eat dumplings, such things were nothing more than what had to be done.

“Good grief. I’ve been a mounted bandit for more than ten years, but I’ve never seen anyone like you. It’s like you don’t have a conscience.”

“Why? I’m a mounted bandit.”

“Kid, that’s not how it usually works. You get used to it little by little. No one is skilled from the very beginning.”

“Were you like that too, Boss? It was easy for me.”

“Easy, easy… I’m starting to wonder if I’m raising a tiger cub. How about learning a thing or two about martial arts from me?”

“Martial arts?”

“Yes, martial arts. You’re still young, so if your bones and martial talent are up to the task, you could become a master.”

“Then I’ll call you Master from today onward.”

“Master and disciple, my ass. Forget it. Just keep doing what you’re doing now.”

Not forming a master-disciple relationship had been the right decision.

A year later, his boss was beheaded by a First Rate master, and Pung Yang found a new nest in another mounted-bandit group.

"You were under Gwangchil?"

"Yes. As long as you feed me well, I'll swear my loyalty to you."

"You seem reasonably sharp. I won't go easy on you just because you're young, so keep up on your own."

Gaoyuan was brutal.

Entire mounted-bandit groups were sometimes wiped out after attacking the wrong merchant caravan, and power struggles between the groups never ceased.

But Pung Yang survived every time, growing stronger with each passing year.

By the time he turned thirty, his martial arts had entered the First Rate realm, and he managed to seize the position of squad leader in a mounted-bandit group of considerable size.

But that was as far as I got.

The law of strength applied everywhere.

Gaoyuan was ultimately just another part of the Murim, where the strong ruled.

Pung Yang possessed grand ambitions and an exceptional mind, but he lacked the martial power befitting a leader.

The limit of Third Rate martial arts.

Pung Yang's martial talent was extraordinary.

Had he entered a prestigious orthodox sect as a child and learned an excellent internal cultivation technique and martial arts, he might have crossed the wall to Peak long ago.

But he had grown up in a beggars' den and learned Third Rate martial arts from the mounted bandits of Gaoyuan. His limits were clear.

If heaven's fortune hadn't favored me, I'd probably still be stuck in the same place.

A deep smile settled over Pung Yang's lips.

Three years ago, on that day, his life had changed completely. He had gone from being a mere squad leader in a mounted-bandit group to the leader of the Red Wind Band, one of the powers moving Gaoyuan—and now it was time to swallow a Murim sect.

"Leader!"

His subordinate's shout snapped Pung Yang out of his thoughts.

Far in the distance, stone walls piled high like a fortress had finally come into view.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect.

As Pung Yang gazed at his and the Red Wind Band's new home, one person entered his sight. Even from this distance, he could feel the man's fiery aura.

The Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek.

The wall he had to overcome to take the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Although he had withdrawn after suffering a slight loss last time…

Today will be different.

Pung Yang unconsciously felt inside his robes. After confirming the hard wooden case there, his smile deepened.

“Leader, your orders?”

“Surround them. Don’t let so much as a single ant escape. Then send an envoy.”

Total destruction or marriage.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had only two choices.

“I’ll have the Mount Heng Sword Sect in my hands before sunset.”

“They’ve surrounded our sect without leaving a gap!”

“Their numbers are well over two hundred!”

“Sect Leader, please make a decision!”

Seated in the place of honor, Lee Seowol spoke calmly.

“Are the troops deployed?”

“Of the hundred or so men, half are blocking the sect entrance. The rest have been armed with shields and bows.”

Everyone in the main hall knew that “a hundred or so” was a generous estimate. In truth, they fell well short of that number.

Several of the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s senior figures had fled the previous night, taking their families and the subordinates who followed them.

“Uncle Cheol, what happened with what I asked you to do?”

“I took care of it as you instructed.”

Lee Seowol’s plan involved oil.

They had spread enough oil to fill ten wagons evenly throughout the estate.

They had covered it with piles of well-dried hay, so it was obvious that the entire area would turn into a sea of flames the moment fire touched it.

Does she intend to take them down with us?

Cheol Mubaek was worried, but he kept his thoughts to himself. In all the years he had watched Lee Seowol, she had always been calm and clever, even from a very young age.

“We only need to hold out for one day. Just one day. Reinforcements from the Jin Family of Taiyuan are on their way. If we can delay the enemy until then, we have a good chance of winning.”

“R-reinforcements from the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“I hear the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi and the Heaven Shaking Sword are coming in person.”

The faces of everyone gathered in the main hall brightened.

The Heaven Shaking Sword, Jin Mukyung, was already renowned throughout the Central Plains as a martial arts genius, while the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung, was a rising star.

It was uncomfortable that he had earned his fame through a war against the Mount Heng Sword Sect, but knowing that he was now on their side made it feel as though they had gained a thousand troops.

Above all else…

“No matter how bold Pung Yang is, he won’t dare raise his sword against a direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“…I suppose not.”

Lee Seowol felt bitter inside.

Not long ago, the Mount Heng Sword Sect had stood shoulder to shoulder with the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Now, a Murim sect that had once commanded northern Shanxi had to focus all its strength on merely holding out against a mounted-bandit group.

I will never forget what happened today.

Just as she bit down hard on her lip, the doors to the main hall opened, and a martial artist from the Gate Guard Pavilion came running in, shouting.

“Sect Leader, the enemy has sent an envoy!”

“An envoy?”

“Yes. He says there’s something he wishes to tell you in person…”

Lee Seowol nodded without hesitation.

If they could delay the battle by even fifteen minutes, they had to do everything they could.

“Bring him in.”

Not long after the Gate Guard Pavilion martial artist withdrew, the Red Wind Band’s envoy was escorted into the main hall.

Flashing his rotten teeth in a crooked grin, he bowed deeply in an exaggerated manner.

“I pay my respects to the Sect Leader of the great Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

His attitude was clearly mocking, but the senior figures—and even the fiery-tempered Cheol Mubaek—suppressed their anger. Lee Seowol had repeatedly warned them beforehand.

“Why did you send an envoy?”

“Well, shouldn’t you offer a man who has traveled so far a bowl of rice wine before you start asking—gasp!”

The Red Wind Band’s envoy broke off and began trembling violently.

Unable to contain his anger, Cheol Mubaek had taken one step forward and unleashed an overwhelming aura.

“Do you want rice wine that badly?”

At the deep, heavy voice, the envoy frantically shook his head.

“N-no, sir. I was thirsty and said something stu—stupid.”

“Uncle Cheol. That’s enough.”

“…Hmph. Stop talking nonsense and deliver your message.”

Barely freed from Cheol Mubaek’s aura, the envoy stammered.

“T-the Leader says we should end this pointless war and cement our friendship.”

“Friendship?”

The senior figures of the Mount Heng Sword Sect doubted their own ears.

Who had betrayed the previous Sect Leader, Lee Cheonbaek, and killed even the Young Sect Leader, Lee Seogwang? And hadn’t they massacred the families and dependents of the Datong Branch only a short while ago?

But Lee Seowol reacted differently. Without the slightest hint of surprise, she stared straight at the envoy.

“And if we refuse?”

“He said you won’t escape total destruction.”

“So he means that if we want to save our people, we must offer the Mount Heng Sword Sect in its entirety as a wedding gift.”

“I-I don’t know anything beyond that…”

By now, everyone in the main hall understood what Pung Yang had meant by “friendship.”

They were all furious, but the first to act was the Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek.

Thud!

In the literal blink of an eye, Cheol Mubaek crossed more than ten *jang*[695] and drove his fist into the envoy’s chest.

The red Fist Energy carrying horrifying heat shattered his chest bones and burned his blood and flesh.

“Ghuuuh…”

With one final death rattle, the light vanished from the envoy’s eyes.

Cheol Mubaek pulled his fist from the man’s chest and turned toward Lee Seowol.

“He deserved to die a hundred times over.”

“I agree. But…”

Lee Seowol slowly rose from her seat and continued.

“Now there’s no avoiding the fight.”

One hour later, everyone in the Mount Heng Sword Sect heard the sound of horn calls ringing out from all directions.

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[695] *Jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 113

Half a shichen[696] after sending an envoy to the Mount Heng Sword Sect, Pung Yang gave the order without hesitation.

“Attack.”

A swift, decisive battle.

The longer it dragged on, the worse it would be for him. Word that the Red Wind Band had surrounded the Mount Heng Sword Sect would spread quickly, and if outside forces—especially the Jin Family of Taiyuan—intervened, things would become troublesome.

I never expected to enter without bloodshed in the first place.

She might be a woman, but she carried the blood of the Blood Wolf Sword, Lee Cheonbaek.

If words and gestures couldn’t tame her, he would have to subdue her with violence—the same method Pung Yang had always used.

Bwooooooong!

Powerful horn calls rang out from every direction. At the advance signal used by the mounted-bandit groups of Gaoyuan, the mounted bandits of the Red Wind Band surrounding the Mount Heng Sword Sect kicked their horses in the ribs as one.

“Chaaaarge!”

“Kill every last one of them!”

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

Hundreds of hooves raced forward, trampling the snow-covered ground.

The horn calls continued without pause, strong and carrying far into the distance.

Ding!

SYSTEM

Circulate Qi was successfully completed.
A small amount of Fatigue and Stamina has been restored.

The moment I heard the System notification and opened my eyes, I looked around.

“Did you guys just hear something?”

Wolhwa and Hyuk Mujin, who had been feeding hay to the horses, looked at me in confusion.

[696] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"Young Master Jin, what sound?"

"There's always sound. Listen—the horses chewing hay, the wind…"

"Not that crap, you idiot."

"Then what?"

"A-a vuvuzela?"

"Vuvu… what?"

"The thing people use to cheer at sporting events… Never mind. It's a thing."

I gave up trying to explain and stared in the direction the sound had come from—or rather, the direction I thought it had come from.

Coincidentally, it was north, toward the Mount Heng Sword Sect—the very direction we were heading.

Did I hear it wrong?

According to Wolhwa, we still had another three shichen—six hours—of riding before we reached the Mount Heng Sword Sect. Whatever had happened, we were too far away to hear it from here.

Unless it was cannon fire.

Jin Mukyung, who had just finished circulating his qi, added his opinion.

"I didn't hear anything."

"But I could've sworn I heard something."

"You imagined it."

"Something might have happened at the Mount Heng Sword Sect."

"That's possible. But I didn't hear anything."

"But I'm telling you, I think I heard something."

"So I'm telling you that you imagined it."

"Based on what?"

"It's simple. There's no way you heard something I couldn't."

"…"

That was incredibly irritating, but he was right, so I couldn't argue.

Seeing me at a loss for words, Jin Mukyung clicked his tongue.

"If you don't want to die to a stray blade, focus on keeping your mind and body under control. You never know what might happen on a battlefield."

Look who's lecturing whom.

When it came to combat experience, no one here could match me.

I only looked the same as usual because I had grown so accustomed to it. When it came to preparing for and taking part in battle, I was already thoroughly battle-hardened.

“There are a lot of enemies, so conserve as much internal energy as possible and keep your movements to a minimum. I’ll take the lead. Just follow me, and you’ll be fine.”

Was he worried about me because we shared the same blood?

Come to think of it, Mukyung had made his dislike painfully obvious, yet he had still helped me a great deal.

He had helped with my training, agreed to accompany me to the Mount Heng Sword Sect, and, I’d heard, had even put considerable effort into reforming his lazy little brother when they were children.

Even if Jin Wikyung had asked him to, he couldn’t have done all that if he truly hated me.

Maybe he’s actually a soft-hearted guy.

Was this what people called a tsundere?[697]

I gazed at Jin Mukyung sentimentally, almost feeling a little moved.

Our eyes met.

“What are you looking at? Eyes down.”

“…”

“If you take even a single wound from those mounted-bandit bastards, I’ll kill you myself.”

“…Yeah, sure.”

That’s more like it. Tsundere, my ass.

I must have lost my mind for a moment to imagine something so ridiculous.

Accepting reality, I was about to transfer my saddle to one of the spare horses we had taken earlier when Hyuk Mujin sidled over with a deeply worried expression.

“Second Young Master, you aren’t going to kill me too, are you?”

“…Are you saying it’s okay if I die?”

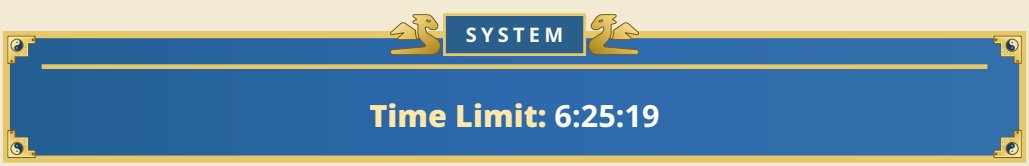
“Ah, no! Why would you put it like that?”

“I’ll make sure to kill you before I die, so shut up and get ready to leave.”

I kicked Hyuk Mujin in the rear as he grumbled under his breath, then mounted my horse.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect was still three shichen away.

From here on, we had to ride hard without taking a single break.



[697] *Tsundere* is a Japanese term for someone who acts cold or hostile while concealing affection.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect was like a fortress. Its towering stone walls were sturdy enough to be called castle walls, and they were fitted with all manner of defensive structures for withstanding a siege.

Built more than thirty years ago under the uncompromising will of the founding Sect Leader, Lee Cheonbaek, those defenses were finally serving their purpose.

“Fire!”

Whoosh—whoosh—whoosh!

Dozens of arrows loosed in unison rained down on the charging cavalry.

But the most common weapons in Gaoyuan were spears, sabers, and bows. Accustomed to fighting in Gaoyuan, the mounted bandits of the Red Wind Band raised the shields strapped to one arm before anyone even gave the order.

Thud! Thump!

Only a dozen or so men fell from their horses.

The shields, made from bone-dry wood faced with hide from an old horse’s rump, stopped the arrows admirably.

“Ha ha ha! These punks don’t know their elders when they see them, and they dare—!”

That was when it happened.

Fwoosh—crack!

Something hurtled through the air with ferocious momentum, pierced the horse’s neck, and buried itself in the captain’s chest.

Having only just entered the early stages of First Rate, he stared at the arrow protruding from his chest as though he couldn’t believe it, then toppled over together with his prized horse.

Several of the riders behind him lost formation and fell one after another.

“Crossbows! Watch for the crossbows!”

“Return fire!”

Whoosh—whoosh—whoosh!

If the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s attack had been a passing shower, the Red Wind Band’s barrage was a torrential downpour.

Even on horseback, they drew and loosed without pause. Their arrows flew fast and true.

Thwack! Thwack! Thwack!

“Aaargh!”

“Hide behind your shields! Don’t stick your heads out!”

Taking advantage of the opening, the mounted bandits spurred their horses forward and set grappling hooks and makeshift ladders against the walls, which

stood more than ten *jang*[698] high. They began attempting to breach the fortress.

A melee erupted atop the walls.

Screams and blood burst forth.

“Ha ha! Kill them all!”

“Don’t let them climb up!”

Lee Seowol watched it all from the highest watchtower. Her lips trembled, and the color had drained from her face.

So this is the Murim.

The screams of the dying. The desperate struggles of those who wanted to live.

The world of the strong preying on the weak that she had finally encountered was more brutal and frightening than she had imagined.

But…

I can’t retreat.

Countless people had already died. Those who were going to leave had left, while those who remained were fighting with their lives on the line.

Lee Seowol was now the Sect Leader who had to lead them, and she was bound to share her fate with the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

“Sect Leader! The walls are in danger! We need to send reinforcements!”

“They’re breaking down the gate with a battering ram!”

“Sect Leader! You must do something!”

“Sect Leader!”

As urgent reports rained down from every direction, Lee Seowol spoke.

“When I give the signal, fire one fire arrow toward the walls and two toward the gate. And, Uncle Cheol.”

Cheol Mubaek, who had been standing guard beside her, answered.

“Tell me what you need.”

“The gate will be breached soon. Can you buy us a little time?”

“By myself?”

“I can only apologize for making such a difficult request.”

“One against a hundred. I’ve always wanted to try that.”

“The uncle I know is a master who can face ten thousand men. Still, please be careful.”

“All right. Do you really think those bastards could get the better of me?”

Cheol Mubaek laughed heartily and leaped down.

With the Tiger of Mount Heng—a consummate Peak master—guarding the gate, no one would get through unless Pung Yang himself stepped forward.

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[698] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten *jang* is about 30 m (99 ft); a hundred *jang* is about 303 m (994 ft).

More. Just a little longer.

Lee Seowol gazed down at the fierce battle before suddenly shouting like a thunderclap.

“Now!”

The two martial artists who had been waiting for her command each drew their bowstrings.

The next moment, the fire arrows soared into the darkening winter sky and shone brightly above everyone’s heads.

The fire arrows falling like meteors were clearly visible even to Pung Yang, more than a hundred *jang*[699] away.

He muttered to himself.

“So they had a move hidden up their sleeve.”

It didn’t take long for his guess to become certainty.

A moment later, enormous flames erupted around the walls.

Fwoosh! Fwoooosh!

“Aaargh!”

Burning alive was one of the most painful ways to die.

The mounted bandits of the Red Wind Band, massed beneath the walls like a swarm of ants, writhed and screamed horribly.

The ropes attached to the grappling hooks snapped, and the wooden ladders were engulfed in flames.

“Attack!”

“Kill every last one of those mounted-bandit bastards!”

Those waiting below to climb and those still climbing burned to death, while those who had already reached the top were stabbed and slashed by weapons converging from every direction.

“So they did make some preparations…”

As Pung Yang stared impassively at the battlefield, a mounted bandit returned, his body blackened in patches like charcoal.

“What happened?”

“L-Leader. Our losses are too great!”

The moment he reached Pung Yang, the mounted bandit threw himself flat on the ground and continued breathlessly.

[699] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten *jang* is about 30 m (99 ft); a hundred *jang* is about 303 m (994 ft).

“From the first assault until now, at least a hundred men must have died. More importantly, after that fire attack, our brothers’ morale is…”

“The gate?”

“Pardon?”

“What happened to the gate?”

“We broke through, but the Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, is holding it alone…”

“Alone?”

“Yes. His martial arts are so formidable that no one dares step forward.”

“Then that’s enough.”

As he spoke, Pung Yang held out his hand.

The mounted bandit instinctively reached to take it, only for his body to tilt and collapse.

A dagger was buried deep between his brows, his expression frozen in confusion.

“How many troops do we have left?”

The subordinate who served as Pung Yang’s right hand was accustomed to such sights. He glanced at the corpse and answered.

“By a rough count, a little over a hundred and fifty but not quite two hundred. It’s true that our losses are heavier.”

“How much worse do you think theirs are? The men on those walls are the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s final bulwark.”

“You mean those few men are all they have left?”

“Yes.”

“It isn’t that I doubt you, Leader, but what if they have another trap like that fire attack…?”

“That’s what they’re counting on.”

Pung Yang let out a derisive laugh. He didn’t know whose strategy it had been, but they had played it quite cleverly.

If he had been less experienced, Pung Yang too would have suspected another trap and pulled his forces back.

They’re struggling to buy time. Are they waiting for someone’s support?

If so, there was even less reason to hesitate.

The few could not stand against the many. Even after suffering considerable losses, the Red Wind Band would have no trouble wiping out the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

And besides…

“I’m going myself.”

“You’re going yourself, Leader?”

“Yes. We have a tiger to catch, don’t we?”

Pung Yang burst into a hearty laugh and felt inside his robes out of habit.
A hard wooden case rested there.
Inside was something that could bring down a tiger in one go.

Chapter 114

The Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, stood like an iron tower.

The entrance gaped wide enough for two carriages to pass through side by side, yet not one of the fifty-odd mounted bandits of the Red Wind Band dared set foot inside.

They had seen clearly how the men who went ahead of them had died.

Some had died with their heads blown apart. Others had been pierced through the abdomen or killed when their limbs were broken. No one had properly seen when or how Cheol Mubaek's fist moved.

More than twenty had died that way.

"Monster…"

A deep voice from behind rescued the mounted bandits, who were paralyzed with fear.

"You may leave now. I'll handle this place."

At the appearance of the voice's owner, Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader, the mounted bandits retreated like the tide going out. Only then did the two Peak masters face each other.

"Good to see you again, Senior Cheol."

"I don't recall ever taking a bandit as my junior."

"You're still as prickly as ever. They say even brushing sleeves creates a bond, and you and I have traded blows, haven't we?"

"We did. Then you ran away without even looking back."

"Let's call it a strategic retreat. I didn't expect you to show up there either, Senior Cheol."

"Have your internal injuries healed?"

"My insides were burning, so I had a rough few days. But it wasn't enough to kill me, which is why I've shamelessly come back."

"Today, it won't end with mere heat."

"Oh, dear. How about we settle this through conversation? For a man of your age to have such a fiery temper…"

At Pung Yang's shameless remark, Cheol Mubaek ground his teeth.

"Conversation? If you hadn't betrayed us, Lee Cheonbaek, my friend, might have lived."

"I'm not stupid enough to join a fight with no chance of winning."

"As if that weren't enough, you killed Lee Seogwang too?"

"I'm not softhearted enough to spare a brat who came at me without knowing his place."

Pung Yang smiled gently and continued.

“If I’d known that brat would become my brother-in-law, I might have spared him.”

“You bastard!”

A lava-like aura boiled up from every inch of Cheol Mubaek’s body. Under the formidable Scorching Yang Qi of a Peak master, the snow blanketing the ground melted away, and the vegetation turned yellow.

Pung Yang exclaimed in admiration at the sight.

“Your internal energy is remarkable, as expected. If Senior Cheol had only set his mind to it, I’d be facing the Mount Heng Fist Sect today.”

“I’ll rip off your limbs.”

“Still, you shouldn’t be too confident.”

“Don’t count on the same stroke of luck as last time. You have no one to use as a shield today.”

Pung Yang smiled faintly.

“Why do you think I sent my men away?”

“That…”

Cheol Mubaek hesitated. Pung Yang’s relaxed attitude had been bothering him for some time.

What is he plotting?

Last time, Pung Yang had withdrawn after suffering internal injuries in barely a hundred exchanges. The fact that the man who had used his subordinates as shields to escape had sent everyone away and come here of his own accord meant that he was confident enough to do so…

“What dirty trick are you planning?”

“A dirty trick? I simply couldn’t use a chicken-killing knife on a tiger, so I stepped in myself.”

“You? Alone?”

“Why not?”

“There’s no way. I’m grateful, if anything.”

Cheol Mubaek glared at Pung Yang suspiciously and clenched his fists.

“Thanks to you, this will be over easily.”

Whoooosh!

The instant he finished speaking, a scorching gale rushed straight toward Pung Yang. Pung Yang swallowed a breath and swung his curved saber at the red fist energy flying toward his chest.

Boom! Boom-boom!

The two Peak masters collided. Roaring explosions rang out one after another, and the resulting wind swept across the snow-covered ground.

Beneath a mound of snow that had leaped high into the air, one man staggered backward.

"Ugh."

Pung Yang swallowed a groan and looked at his torn palm. He had avoided the disgrace of dropping his weapon, but the difference in strength was undeniable.

"You're still as strong as ever."

Cheol Mubaek stepped toward him and answered.

"It's too late for regrets."

"My thoughts exactly."

"I'll start by tearing that mouth apart."

Fwooooooosh!

Cheol Mubaek lunged forward with the movements of a tiger.

The ferocious forms of the Shura[700] Annihilating Fist, a martial art thought to have been lost long ago, poured down upon Pung Yang.

Kwa-gwa-gwang!

A fierce bloody battle was raging along the fortress walls. Despite facing a four-to-one disadvantage in numbers, the martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect refused to retreat.

"Retreat, and all that awaits us is death!"

"Are you going to let those mounted-bandit bastards steal our home?"

"Let's avenge the martial brothers they killed!"

Slash! Thrust!

"Aaargh!"

"D-don't push!"

The mounted bandits of the Red Wind Band had fallen into confusion. The effects of the earlier fire attack and the fear that another trap might be waiting held them back.

In stark contrast, the martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect charged at them wild-eyed. The mounted bandits were helpless against their unstoppable momentum and were cut down one after another.

"Don't run away!"

"Any bastard who retreats dies by my hand!"

The mounted-bandit captains shouted at the top of their lungs, but they were unable to restore order. Instead, they too had to surrender their lives to arrows that seemed to fly out of nowhere.

[700] Shura derives from *asura*, a class of combative beings in Buddhist and Hindu traditions.

Thwack!

“Ghk. Gaaah…”

“C-Captain!”

Lee Seowol stood atop the highest watchtower, drawing her bowstring without pause.

Beside her were the five finest archers among the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s martial artists.

Twung! Thud!

Every time a bowstring was drawn, a mounted bandit fell. Captains, or those who appeared to rank even higher, were their highest-priority targets.

One more. One more.

But the battle was going worse than expected.

The martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect had entered the battle with fewer troops from the very beginning. They grew exhausted at an alarming rate, and before long, one or two at a time began losing their lives to stray blades.

The mounted bandits, meanwhile, were gradually recovering from their confusion.

“Get a grip! There aren’t many of these Mount Heng Sword Sect bastards!”

“If we kill these men, victory is ours!”

The martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect had nothing left to lose. They fought desperately, heedless of the odds against them.

“Kill them!”

Slash! Slash! Slash!

But every time one mounted bandit was cut down, two more appeared to fill the gap. When two were cut down, three took their place.

“Gasp, gasp!”

A martial artist of the Mount Heng Sword Sect swung his sword frantically, only to be hacked apart by five or six weapons that sprang at him from every direction.

Slash! Thud-thud-thud!

Neck, chest, abdomen… Martial artists were cut and pierced all over, dying without even having time to scream.

The mounted bandits of the Red Wind Band, their momentum rising, continued pressing the attack without pause. Before anyone realized it, half the fortress wall was packed with enemies.

“Haa, haa.”

Twung! Twung! Twung!

Lee Seowol summoned every last bit of strength she had and drew her bowstring. Blood ran from her once-delicate fingers and between her clenched teeth, while her parched mouth reeked of a sickly sweetness.

"There!"

After firing arrows without rest, her position was discovered before long. When about twenty mounted bandits raised their shields and charged toward the watchtower, desperate shouts rang out.

"Sect Leader!"

"You must get away! They're coming!"

Three shichen[701] had passed since the siege began. Lee Seowol had only practiced archery as a hobby. She was no martial artist, and her Stamina had reached its limit long ago.

But she did not stop. She forced strength into her thin, trembling arms and searched for her next target.

Get away? Where would I go?

She had lived here her entire life. To Lee Seowol, the Mount Heng Sword Sect was both her hometown and something she had to protect until the final moment of her life.

The same was true of the martial artists still making their last stand.

"Stop them!"

"Never let them reach the Sect Leader!"

Their desperate cries were in vain. The fortress walls had already been overrun.

The surviving martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect retreated to the watchtower. But well over a hundred mounted bandits were closing in from every direction.

Eyes gleaming with killing intent and desire shone between the torches held by the advancing enemies.

"You damned bastards dare…"

"I'll tear every last one of you apart and throw the pieces to the dogs."

The killing intent of the mounted bandits surrounding the watchtower in a circle stabbed at their skin.

Just as everyone was falling into despair, Lee Seowol suddenly drew her bowstring toward the sky.

Whoooosh.

Trailing a tail of flame, a single fire arrow descended toward the gate shrouded in darkness.

It was a light meant to find one person.

Uncle Cheol.

The Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek.

He was the Mount Heng Sword Sect's final hope.

---

[701] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen are approximately six hours.

That was when a man walked out beneath the light revealed by the fire arrow.

Clomp. Clomp.

“I suppose it’s a little late to say this now…”

Lee Seowol had heard that voice only once, but she could never forget it, not even in her dreams.

Unable to bring herself to look at him, she closed her eyes.

Pung Yang beamed at her.

“You’ll have to marry me.”

The hunter Cheol Mubaek had become the Tiger of Mount Heng because of a fortuitous encounter.

While tracking a wolf on a mountainside in the vast Mount Heng range, he fell into a hidden cave between the cliffs. There, he discovered a martial arts manual and an elixir left behind by a reclusive master.

I’m going back. I’m going back alive, no matter what!

Cheol Mubaek learned martial arts to survive. When the fasting pills in the hidden cave ran out, he tore up grass growing between the cliffs or caught bats to eat as he trained.

After no less than three years, he climbed the cliff with his bare hands and returned to the village.

What awaited him was his home in ruins—and the deaths of his wife and child.

“Had it been two months or so since we last heard from you? That bastard Hwang, who’d always had his eye on your wife…”

By the time Cheol Mubaek came to his senses, he had already beaten the village’s great landowner and all his servants to death.

After avenging his family, Cheol Mubaek returned to the hidden cave and resumed his martial arts training. It was a whip he used against himself, and atonement for his family.

How much time had passed like that?

Before he knew it, Cheol Mubaek was being called the Tiger of Mount Heng.

But…

“Huff. Even a tiger would cry.”

Cheol Mubaek panted harshly. His once-brilliant eyes were clouded as if by dark clouds, and his beard was drenched in blood.

I have to hurry. I have to stop that bastard…

But all he had left was his will. With all four limbs broken, his body had already slipped beyond his control. He had displayed martial arts worthy of the title Tiger of Mount Heng, yet he still could not defeat Pung Yang.

How in the world did that bastard…?

The result seemed obvious. Pung Yang had only just entered the Peak realm, barely capable of creating blade qi, while Cheol Mubaek was a Peak master who had reached a mature realm stage.

Pung Yang had been as precarious as a candle in the wind. Then he had suddenly changed after pulling an unidentified wooden case from inside his robes.

The red pill. Yes, that was definitely it.

Cheol Mubaek had made a mistake by retreating because he thought it might be a hidden weapon. After Pung Yang gulped down the pill, he was no longer the mere leader of a mounted-bandit group Cheol Mubaek had known.

How can a human being become that strong?

Cheol Mubaek's eyes trembled as he recalled Pung Yang's movements.

The gap between them was so vast that it seemed impossible to win, even if they fought ten or a hundred more times. Pung Yang had overturned the battle in an instant, broken all four of Cheol Mubaek's limbs, inflicted massive internal injuries, and then left.

"I'll let you live for now. I've decided I want the formula for your martial art as a wedding gift."

Cheol Mubaek's eyes reddened as he recalled Pung Yang's parting words.

The Shura[702] Annihilating Fist was a martial art passed down to a single successor and never taught to outsiders.

He would choose suicide rather than hand it over to Pung Yang, but Lee Seowol—whom he cherished like a daughter and a granddaughter—troubled him.

What on earth am I supposed to do?

Cheol Mubaek was staring at the sky with a heavy heart when it happened.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The sound of hooves in the distance drew closer and closer before stopping abruptly at his feet.

Beneath the brilliantly shining moon, four pairs of eyes looked down at him.

"Doesn't the Red Wind Band have a retirement age? Why is an old geezer still out here playing bandit?"

"Young Master Jin, that's Great Hero Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng."

"Gah! I'm sorry. Hey, Mujin. Hurry up and apologize. What are you waiting for?"

"You're the one who made the mistake, Captain. Why should I…?"

Smack!

"Grandpa—no, Sir. Are you all right?"

Instead of answering, Cheol Mubaek stared intently at the young man's chest.

[702] Shura derives from *asura*, a class of combative beings in Buddhist and Hindu traditions.

A single character was embroidered on his navy martial robe.

□.[703]

“Taiyuan… the Jin Family?”

“Oh, you recognize it?”

The young man, Jin Taekyung, grinned.

[703] □ is pronounced *Jin* in Korean and means “advance.”

Chapter 115

Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng.

I had heard that name several times already. Wolhwa had said that without him, the Mount Heng Sword Sect would have been wiped out by the Red Wind Band long ago.

“He’s considered a Peak master comparable to or even stronger than the Blood Wolf Sword, Lee Cheonbaek.”

She had definitely said that.

Then why has such an incredible Peak master ended up like this?

His limbs were bent at unnatural angles, and the black blood soaking his shirt was proof of severe internal injuries. Cheol Mubaek looked at us through hazy eyes.

“Taiyuan… Jin Family?”

“Oh, you recognize us?”

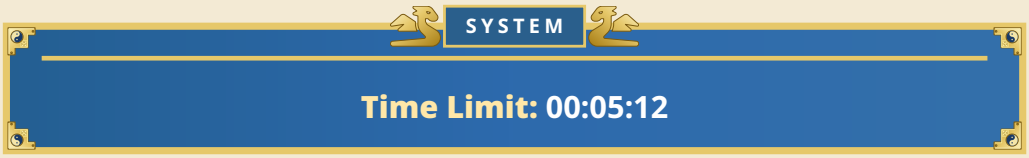
I forced a smile, hoping to reassure the critically wounded Cheol Mubaek, if only a little.

The man before me was no longer a renowned Peak master of formidable reputation. He was nothing more than an old man who had found his last hope.

“Red Wind Band… inside… Seowol’s in danger…”

Even without hearing Cheol Mubaek’s halting words, everyone here understood how serious the situation was. Everywhere we looked, there were corpses and pools of blood.

But it’s not too late yet.



We had made it just in time. The problem was that the bastard who had reduced the Tiger of Mount Heng to this state was still inside.

Wolhwa seemed to be thinking the same thing. She calmed Cheol Mubaek as she asked,

“Sir Cheol, did Pung Yang join forces with another master to attack you?”

Cheol Mubaek weakly shook his head.

“You’re saying Pung Yang defeated you by himself?”

“R-red pill. Be careful of that bastard…”

A red pill?

I wanted to ask more, but Cheol Mubaek had reached his limit. His lips moved soundlessly before his head slumped forward. Hyuk Mujin sucked in a startled breath.

“H-he’s dead.”

“…He’s still alive.”

“Oh. So he is. His breathing was so faint that I…”

Hyuk Mujin, you bastard. What kind of person kills even the living?

Still, he wasn’t entirely wrong. Cheol Mubaek’s thin breath was so precarious that it could stop at any moment.

That was when Wolhwa pulled a small porcelain bottle from inside her robes.

“Could you lift his head a little?”

She tipped the bottle into the unconscious Cheol Mubaek’s mouth.

As an unidentified green liquid trickled down his throat, color gradually returned to his pale face. It seemed to be a remarkably effective medicine.

“This will help him catch his breath, but it’s only a temporary measure. In his current condition, he couldn’t even handle a child. You understand, right?”

In short, someone had to stay behind to protect Cheol Mubaek in case something happened. I nodded without hesitation.

“Then Mujin can—”

“Two people stay behind.”

“Huh? Two people?”

What was he talking about? Jin Mukyung met my gaze, looking as though he couldn’t see what the problem was.

“Why?”

“No, you mean just the two of us should go?”

“Is there a problem?”

…

Of course there was.

Pung Yang turned a formidable Peak master like Cheol Mubaek into a half-dead wreck, and he still has all those mounted-bandit bastards under his command.

We needed every hand we could get, and he was suggesting this?

I didn’t know about Hyuk Mujin, whose abilities were still questionable, but Wolhwa absolutely had to come with us.

“Can the two of you manage?” Wolhwa asked.

I hurriedly opened my mouth.

“Obviously, that’s—”

“We can.”

Just as I was about to say it was impossible, Jin Mukyung fixed his deep, dark eyes on me.

“I said we can. Trust me.”

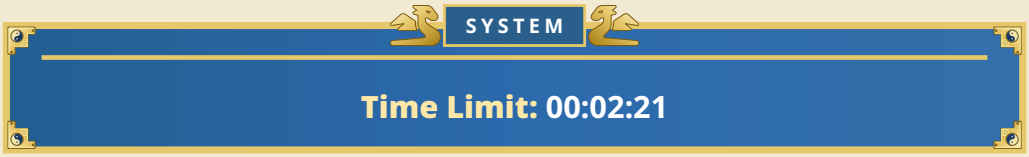
His calm yet confident words left me speechless.

For a moment, I wondered if this was merely the reckless bravado of an immature young man. But then I realized I was shaking my head inwardly.

The Heaven Shaking Sword. A martial arts genius.

The guy standing before me was a monster born from the combination of effort and talent. From everything I had seen, he wasn’t foolish enough to throw his life away for nothing.

And…



Damn it. There was no time left to hesitate.

I let out a deep sigh and asked Jin Mukyung,

“Are you confident?”

“This is the best option. Anyone of middling skill would only become a burden.”

Wolhwa let out a quiet laugh.

“My, you’re awfully honest.”

“…I apologize for that.”

“Well, that’s all right. You’re not wrong.”

That was the first time I had ever seen him apologize to anyone.

Hyuk Mujin interrupted this rare spectacle.

“Second Young Master, I’m a martial artist too!”

“Then follow us. But you’ll be responsible for staying alive.”

“On my own…?”

“I guarantee that once the fighting begins, the enemy will target you first. There’s nothing wrong with fighting bravely as a martial artist and dying.”

After a brief silence, Hyuk Mujin answered with a resolute expression.

“As a martial artist, I will remain here and safely protect Sir Cheol, who walks the same martial path as I do.”

…

Sometimes I wondered if that guy was even human.

If I had the time, I’d beat the hell out of him.

But even now, time continued to pass.

SYSTEM

Time Limit: 00:01:09

“Whew.”

I tightened my grip on the spear I had already taken out and spoke to Jin Mukyung.

“I’ll handle the small fry.”

“Usually, at a time like this, aren’t you supposed to volunteer to take the leader?”

“Yeah. Throw away that stereotype.”

“You’re ridiculous.”

“Let’s just say I know my place.”

“Fighting spirit and competitive pride help a martial artist grow.”

“And hasten his death. I’ve learned to pick my opponents carefully, so use all that overflowing fighting spirit and competitive pride to deal with Pung Yang.”

“You certainly have a way with words.”

“Oh, and when we get inside, approach as quietly as possible. Then ambush them when I give the signal. Got it?”

“Ambush?”

“Use the essence of an ambush to inflict as much damage as possible at the beginning. While the enemies are thrown into confusion, we’ll get to the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect…”

“I see.”

“Good. It’s nice to be understood for once.”

That took care of the preparations. Forty seconds. Thirty-nine. Thirty-eight.

I watched the numbers fall and was about to head for the gate when—

Clomp.

There wasn’t even time to stop him.

Jin Mukyung strode inside and unleashed a shout infused with internal energy.

“Pung Yang!”

SYSTEM

Time Limit has disappeared.

…

Jin Mukyung, you fucking asshole.

“Marriage? I’d rather die.”

Pung Yang clicked his tongue as he watched Lee Seowol draw a silver dagger and hold it to her own throat.

“You’re making this awfully difficult. You really are the Blood Wolf Sword’s daughter.”

Though Pung Yang was highly skilled with throwing knives, he couldn’t make full use of his specialty in his current condition.

Damn old man… He actually forced me to use a Temporary Strength Pill.

Even Pung Yang possessed only three of these precious pills. Using one had allowed him to defeat Cheol Mubaek, but the aftereffects were considerable.

He hid his hands, trembling like aspen leaves, beneath his sleeves and said,

“Bring everyone who’s still breathing.”

“Yes.”

Not long after the order was given, martial artists from the Mount Heng Sword Sect were dragged over, bound hand and foot. Darkness settled over Lee Seowol’s face.

“What are you planning to do?”

Pung Yang smiled.

“You can probably guess. First, I’ll cut off their limbs one by one in front of you. Arms, legs, this and that. It won’t be a pleasant sight, so I recommend closing your eyes.”

“If you do that…”

“If you intend to kill yourself, I won’t stop you. Your loyal subordinates will be slaughtered in return, though.”

Lee Seowol clenched her teeth.

“That isn’t what you want, is it?”

“If my bride-to-be says she’s going to die, what else can I do? Still, the Blood Wolf Sword’s secret martial art and the Tiger of Mount Heng’s martial arts formula would be enough. Ah, I should take that old man Cheol with me on the way back, too.”

“…Uncle Cheol is still alive?”

“Of course. How could I kill a Benefactor who’s going to hand over such a precious martial arts formula?”

“…”

“I’ll stake my life on this promise. It’s not too late even now, so marry me. If you do, I’ll let everyone live. I’ll stop at destroying their dantians.”

That was the decisive blow.

Lee Seowol’s eyelashes trembled for a while before she slowly lowered her hand.

“Keep your promise.”

"A wise choice."

A triumphant smile spread across Pung Yang's face.

As of today, he would begin his third life.

He had gone from a beggar boy to a mounted bandit. Now he would finally don the mask of the orthodox faction and become the true master of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Though there had been heavy losses, it didn't matter. New wine belonged in new wineskins. Under the name of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, he would recruit martial artists and expand his power.

If the Blood Wolf Sword could do it thirty years ago, why can't I?

Just as the corners of his mouth lifted with overflowing delight—

"Pung Yang!"

A shout infused with internal energy shook heaven and earth.

Lee Seowol, Pung Yang, and every survivor turned their heads as if on cue.

A young man dressed in robes as black as night was walking toward them from some fifty *jang* away.[704]

A master.

The young man's needle-sharp gaze sent a chill through a corner of Pung Yang's chest.

He was a master. More than that, he was a Peak master in no way inferior to Pung Yang himself. Pung Yang could tell just from the way the young man's hand moved as it gripped his sword hilt.

There are only two Peak masters this young in Shanxi Province. And if he's a swordsman…

The answer came immediately.

Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword. A genius who had reached the Peak realm at barely twenty years of age.

More importantly, behind him stood the Jin Family of Taiyuan, which had risen to become the foremost family in Shanxi.

At least he came alone.

But the next moment, another person cautiously stuck his head out through the fortress gate Jin Mukyung had entered.

The young man wore a navy martial robe. His clothing, the dark iron spear in his hand, and above all, his nearly identical face told Pung Yang who he was.

"The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

Jin Taekyung flinched at the nickname someone blurted out and muttered, "Fuck. I knew this would happen."

---

[704] A *jang* is a traditional length of 10 *ja*, or 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 150 m (500 ft).

Cursing crudely in a manner unbecoming a scion of a prestigious family, Jin Taekyung came sauntering forward beside the leisurely Jin Mukyung.

The two brothers were heading straight toward Pung Yang.

The Taiyuan Jin Family, at a time like this… This is very bad.

The reputation the family had built over many years, combined with the fame it had earned in the battle at Eight Spring Gorge, had left the Jin Family's current standing unrivaled.

As a result, countless young people across Shanxi Province who dreamed of becoming martial artists were flocking to the Jin Family.

That was why, even if Pung Yang swallowed the Mount Heng Sword Sect right now, he would still have to bow flat and hide his claws.

Once I get past this hurdle, my opportunity will come.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had already collapsed. The Murim was a world where the strong preyed on the weak, and Pung Yang was a new power in that world. Even if his opponent was the Taiyuan Jin Family, he believed he had earned the right to be treated with respect.

Clomp. Clomp. Clomp.

With every step Jin Mukyung and Jin Taekyung took, the Red Wind Band's mounted bandits scattered out of their way.

When the brothers reached him, Pung Yang clasped his hands in salute.

"I am Pung Yang, Red Wind Band Leader."

Had Pung Yang not been a seasoned martial artist who never let down his guard—had the effects of the Temporary Strength Pill not still lingered faintly—he would never have evaded that strike.

Shiiiiing!

He hurriedly twisted aside.

A dazzling streak of Sword Energy skimmed past his neck and sliced through three mounted bandits behind him.

"Is this the will of the Taiyuan Jin Family?"

Jin Taekyung, who had already felled the nearby mounted bandits, muttered, "I'd rather talk it out."

"You fucking bast—"

Shiiiiing! Slice!

Before Pung Yang could finish speaking, another streak of Sword Energy flew in and grazed his back.

Pain seared through him like fire. He barely evaded the attacks that followed and revised his assessment of Jin Mukyung.

He's stronger than me.

At this level, Jin Mukyung's movements were comparable to Cheol Mubaek's. On top of that, Jin Taekyung was slaughtering Pung Yang's subordinates.

Pung Yang realized he had only one option left.

The Temporary Strength Pill.

While his subordinates died one after another trying to stop Jin Mukyung, Pung Yang pulled the wooden case hidden inside his robes and tipped the pill into his mouth.

Shiiiiing!

Jin Mukyung's blue Sword Energy was reflected in Pung Yang's eyes, which had turned blood-red.

Slice!

Chapter 116

The moment Jin Mukyung's Sword Energy split Pung Yang's back, I thought,

We've won.

It was hard to predict the outcome of a life-and-death duel between Peak masters.

But even I, someone who had yet to reach the Peak realm, could clearly see the gap between Jin Mukyung and Pung Yang.

Is Jin Mukyung really that strong, or was Pung Yang weaker than I thought?

Had he exhausted all his strength in his earlier fight with Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng?

What mattered was that Jin Mukyung held an overwhelming advantage.

Slice! Shraaak!

"Gaaaaah!"

Pung Yang retreated, using his subordinates as shields, while Jin Mukyung relentlessly cut his way after him. The Red Wind Band's mounted bandits scattered in every direction to avoid the blue Sword Energy, leaving Pung Yang exposed and alone.

It's over.

I was clenching my fist in triumph when I noticed the red pill in his hand.

Wait. A red pill?

It was the very thing Cheol Mubaek had mentioned. Warning bells rang in my head just as Pung Yang tossed the pill into his mouth.

Jin Mukyung didn't miss the opening. His blue Sword Energy plunged toward the crown of Pung Yang's head.

Shiiiiing! Slice!

Blood sprayed through the air, and a shoulder was deeply cut.

But the person staggering backward was none other than Jin Mukyung.

I blinked.

What the hell just…

What had happened?

The System answered my question.

SYSTEM

A sudden Quest has been generated.
Quest
Temporary Strength Pill
Red Wind Band Leader Pung Yang has taken a Temporary Strength Pill (□□□) and is currently empowered by abnormal strength. Defeat him and save the Mount Heng Sword Sect.
The Quest will fail if Lee Seowol dies!
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Task: Stop or defeat **Lv.??? Pung Yang** (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

A Supreme Peak-grade Quest, no less.

I quickly skimmed the details and understood why that bastard had grown so strong.

“Temporary Strength Pill? Don’t tell me…”

I gaped at Pung Yang.

He looked completely different from before. His eyes had turned completely bloodred. Veins bulged beneath the skin exposed below his sleeves, and his muscles looked ready to burst. On top of that, the sheer force radiating from him made it frightening to even approach.

There’s no mistaking it.

No, fuck…

A fucking Peak master, cheating by doping?

“Heh-heh-heh.”

Pung Yang let out a low laugh.

Power and vitality surged through his entire body. His head burned hotter than ever, and everything in sight seemed weak and insignificant.

The internal energy boiling in his dantian only added to the sensation.

So this is the power of the Temporary Strength Pill.

It was an unknown red pill capable of drawing out twice the strength a person currently possessed—no, even more than that—for a limited time. Pung Yang himself didn’t know who had made it or how.

It was, quite literally, a fortuitous encounter bestowed by the heavens.

The Crimson Blood Twelve Swords. The Crimson Blood Cultivation Technique. And a wooden case containing five Temporary Strength Pills.

There were countless tombs hidden across the vast Gaoyuan. In one of them, Pung Yang had discovered a Peak-level martial arts manual and the Temporary Strength Pills, all left behind by some unknown person. The moment he found them, he knew he had stumbled upon a fortuitous encounter.

He also knew such treasures could not be shared with anyone.

Even if I went back to that time ten times, I would have made the same choice.

After killing his subordinates and claiming the fortuitous encounter for himself, Pung Yang began training in a hidden refuge no one ever visited. In only two years, he reached the Peak realm.

The absurd speed of his growth and the killing intent that surged from him at unpredictable moments made him realize he had learned demonic, heterodox arts.

But he didn't care.

This is the Murim!

In a world where strength was the law, arguing over whether something was orthodox, heterodox, or demonic was laughable. After returning to Gaoyuan, Pung Yang quickly began to distinguish himself.

His intelligence was far beyond that of the other mounted bandits, and his martial arts were exceptional.

By using violence and rewards in just the right measure, he quickly bent his subordinates to his will. Of course, he had faced crises as well.

But Pung Yang possessed a wondrous treasure he had never shown anyone.

That was when I first learned what the Temporary Strength Pill could do.

One against a hundred? It went far beyond that.

After taking a Temporary Strength Pill, he became an invincible master whom no one in Gaoyuan could withstand.

Two major mounted-bandit groups that had tried to eliminate their new rival were wiped out overnight. It was only natural that Pung Yang's Red Wind Band took their place.

But that was as far as I could go.

Demonic, heterodox arts could be learned quickly through shortcuts, but they lacked depth. Just as Pung Yang was trying to make up for that weakness with orthodox martial arts, two places caught his eye: the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

A battle between a dragon and a tiger.

Pung Yang didn't care which one fell.

At first, Lee Cheonbaek had hired him with the martial arts of the Jin Family of Taiyuan promised as payment…

But things had gone awry and led him here.

I should have used a Temporary Strength Pill when I first attacked the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

He could attack the Mount Heng Sword Sect again and force it to submit whenever he wanted.

But he could never obtain another Temporary Strength Pill.

If he had taken one back then, he might already have become the master of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

“Well, this isn’t so bad either. Now I’ll obtain the martial arts of both the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

Jin Mukyung pressed an acupoint on his shoulder to staunch the bleeding, then spoke.

“Was that your goal from the beginning? I thought some mounted-bandit bastard was desperate to play at being a Great Hero of the orthodox faction.”

“A Great Hero? If I kill the Heaven Shaking Sword and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi today, I might at least become a demon lord. Wahaha!”

“You? A demon lord? Don’t make me laugh. And you don’t have to worry about that happening.”

“I broke all four of Cheol Mubaek’s limbs. The way you talk is beyond saving, so I’ll have to cut off two of yours.”

“Oh, really? My younger brother says this a lot…”

Jin Mukyung spat out a wad of phlegm.

“Go fuck yourself.”

Whoosh!

The blue-steel sword looked pathetic with its badly chipped edge, but the moment blue Sword Energy coated it, it transformed into the finest sword under heaven.

Shraaaaak! Shishishiiing!

Sword Energy rained down, slicing through everything around them. Horrible screams erupted from all directions, but Jin Mukyung did not stop swinging.

They were only the screams of mounted bandits who had failed to evade the attacks and gotten caught in them. The man whose voice Jin Mukyung wanted to hear was effortlessly avoiding his sword.

“As expected of the Heaven Shaking Sword. The edge of your sword is fairly sharp.”

Jin Mukyung slashed toward Pung Yang’s waist with lightning speed.

Clang!

Jin Mukyung's Sword Energy-wreathed blade collided with Pung Yang's curved saber, unleashing a thunderous boom.

"It's disgusting hearing that from someone who got stronger through dark arts."

"What matters is that I got stronger. How many seconds do you think that supposedly incredible Tiger of Mount Heng lasted against me?"

"Don't know."

Whoosh!

This time, the attack came for his face. The barrage of strikes that had poured toward his arms, chest, stomach, side, and legs suddenly shot straight upward.

Pung Yang hurriedly pulled his head back. The blade skimmed past his cheek by the narrowest margin.

Sizzle.

But he couldn't avoid even the sharp pressure of the wind. Blood dripped from the cheek the wind had raked.

Pung Yang retreated without a word, checked the wound, and ground his teeth.

"…You little brat."

Jin Mukyung spoke calmly despite the killing intent in Pung Yang's voice.

"So?"

"What?"

"So how many seconds did Sir Cheol last against you?"

Pung Yang glared at Jin Mukyung before answering.

"A hundred seconds."

"What about me?"

"Two hundred seconds. I'll finish you before then."

"Are you even capable of that?"

"Before cutting off your limbs, I should pull out your tongue first. Listening to you has been pissing me off for a while now."

"Be grateful you didn't have to fight my younger brother. If he were your opponent, you'd have already plugged your ears and killed yourself. He's mastered the art of making fun of people."

"The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi? Then I suppose I should pull his tongue out too."

"…That actually sounds kind of appealing."

"Enough nonsense. Raise your sword. That way, you can struggle for even a moment longer before you die."

The instant Pung Yang's red eyes gleamed eerily, immense internal energy surged from his lowered saber.

Fwoooosh!

When internal energy was infused into a medium and given tangible form, it was called Sword Energy.

But after taking the Temporary Strength Pill, Pung Yang had now surpassed that realm.

“Sword Force…”

A Supreme Peak master.

It was the symbol of those known as Martial Gods.

Though his enlightenment was insufficient for it to be called true Sword Force, there was no doubt that he had reached the very pinnacle of the Peak realm.

“Well, damn.”

Jin Mukyung let out a hollow laugh.

How many years would Pung Yang have needed to reach that realm through training alone? Ten? Twenty?

But one tiny red pill had allowed him to leap over all those years—the contemplation of martial principles, the endless training, the blood and sweat.

It had let him surpass all of it.

“What kind of son of a bitch made something like that…”

Tsssss.

Sword Energy rose from Jin Mukyung’s sword as well. Pung Yang spoke with open contempt.

“Last two hundred seconds, and I’ll let you live.”

“Yeah, go fuck yourself.”

Fwoooosh!

As he watched the Sword Force plunge down as though to split heaven and earth, Jin Mukyung suddenly thought he was beginning to resemble his insolent youngest brother.

But what is that guy doing, taking so long to get here?

KABOOOOM!

Rumble, rumble, rumble.

The ground shook as though an earthquake had struck.

I had no idea what kind of battle was taking place thirty jang[705] away, but I knew one thing.

I can’t go over there.

I wasn’t joking. If I got caught up in that fight, I’d probably die.

I had no desire to personally experience what happened when a First Rate got its back broken between Peak masters. And more importantly…

Whoosh! Slice!

[705] A Korean jang is ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty jang is about 90.9 m (298 ft).

"Gueeegh."

I had more than enough on my hands here.

At this point, I might not be able to take on a hundred men, but I had to be good for at least seventy.

I swung my weapon like a madman, drenched in the blood pouring down around me.

Shwaaak!

I caught the cavalry spear thrusting toward my side and pulled it toward me. I drove it into the stomach of the man bringing his saber down behind me, then chopped through the shaft with the edge of my hand.

Crack!

"Gasp!"

"Use an iron spear next time. Something heavy and sturdy. You could even do squats with it. How great is that?"

With that friendly advice, I smashed my fist into the mounted bandit's jaw. His body went limp as his jawbone shattered.

Shraaaaak!

Throat, side, leg.

I could read the daggers thrusting toward me from three directions without even looking.

How could every last one of them be so slow and predictable?

I was also genuinely amazed by myself. In that brief moment, I could think of a response and put it into action.

Tap. Crack!

I put my weapon into my Inventory, freeing my hands. As I simultaneously caught the wrists of the men stabbing toward my throat and side and broke them, I kicked backward with my leg fully extended.

Their short screams and the dull impact told me I had struck exactly where I intended.

More. More. More.

My hands moved faster and faster, while the sounds around me grew more distant.

Every time I brushed against the bodies of the enemies surrounding me, weapons summoned from my Inventory appeared and vanished.

Stab. Slash. Swing.

Broke.

How many had I brought down?

At some point, the noise that had been pushed far away came rushing back all at once.

Thud.

“Ggh…”

“Urgh.”

The dead lay motionless with their faces buried in the cold dirt. The survivors rolled around, groaning. The twenty or so mounted bandits who had escaped death and injury backed away from me.

“T-the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi…”

One step. Two steps.

Terrified, they retreated as I advanced, forgetting that furious enemies were still behind them.

Shraaaaak! Thud!

“Kill them! Kill every last mounted bandit!”

“You fucking bastards!”

They were the martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect who had survived and fought to the bitter end.

Caught by the surprise attack of those bloodshot-eyed men, the mounted bandits fell like dominoes.

“Kyaaaagh!”

“P-please, spare me…!”

Everywhere I looked, the ground overflowed with corpses, blood, and groans.

How many mounted bandits had died here today? Two hundred? Three hundred?

I didn’t know.

What I did know was that this battle would not end until one man died.

Pung Yang.

It was time to deal with that cheating, pill-popping bastard.

“…”

I can do this, right? I should be able to. Probably…

Chapter 117

Jin Mukyung had learned countless martial arts over the years. They ranged from Peak-level arts that had once defined an era to Third Rate martial arts easily found even at a street stall in some backwater village.

But at this very moment, he realized something.

It's strong. Stronger than any martial art I've ever learned.

Fwoooosh.

A curved saber descended with the force of a single slash cleaving something in two.

It wasn't a Supreme Peak art like the Namgung Family's Emperor Sword Form or Huashan's Plum Blossom Sword Technique. This was the first move of the Three Calamities Sword Technique, Mount Tai Presses Down on the Crown—a move even a Third Rate street thug would know.

Pressing down Mount Tai. I think I know what that feels like.

The red saber qi rippling over the blade seemed capable of more than merely pressing down Mount Tai. It looked as though it could split the mountain apart.

I can't block it.

In that split second, Jin Mukyung threw himself aside without hesitation.

Shraaaaak!

The saber qi grazed his clothes by a hair before striking the ground. The sight of the earth splitting wide open without a single boom or tremor sent a shiver through him.

"You dodged that?"

But Pung Yang was dissatisfied with the result.

That had been an all-out attack. Even after drawing out 120 percent of the Temporary Strength Pill's effects, he hadn't managed to leave so much as a scratch on Jin Mukyung.

The Tiger of Mount Heng could barely parry that.

Even Cheol Mubaek, a fully mature Peak master, had suffered internal injuries and been forced to retreat in exchange for blocking it. So how had a brat not even thirty years old managed this?

"So you do live up to the name Heaven Shaking Sword?"

Jin Mukyung adjusted his stance and replied flatly.

"I should at least be able to dodge that much."

"Because you couldn't block it, perhaps?"

A sneer appeared at the corner of Pung Yang's mouth.

"Of course, a young master of the mighty Jin Family of Taiyuan must have been truly desperate to flee by rolling across the ground like a lazy donkey."

Narye tagon. It was a phrase comparing someone to a lazy donkey rolling on the ground. To martial artists from prestigious orthodox factions who valued their dignity, it was practically the ultimate humiliation.

But not to Jin Mukyung.

“Donkey or mule, I don’t care. Does dignity put food on the table?”

“What?”

“Compared to the price of my life, it was cheap. Besides…”

His face had remained impassive the entire time, but now he let out a quiet laugh.

“Why are you laughing?”

“I was just thinking—if there are people who pelt Peak masters with rocks, is rolling across the ground really such a big deal?”

Unable to make sense of the absurd joke, Pung Yang asked without thinking, “Throwing rocks at a Peak master? Are they insane?”

“When I first heard about it, I thought the same thing. But after thinking it over, I realized he was exactly the kind of bastard who would do something like that.”

“I’d like to see the face of this lunatic.”

“You’ll see him soon.”

“What does that mean?”

That was when Pung Yang felt a faint sense of puzzlement.

Shiiiiing!

A sharp aura came from behind him.

He turned around, and the face of a handsome young man was reflected in his red eyes.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

Within the slow flow of time, Jin Taekyung grinned. The iron spear in his hands was already hurtling toward Pung Yang’s chest.

KABOOM!

One Annihilation.

A vortex erupted from the spearhead and swallowed Pung Yang whole.

I was in perfect condition. Leveling up while dealing with the small fry had completely restored my fatigue and Stamina.

The timing was pretty good, too. Pung Yang’s broad, defenseless back looked like it was begging me to stick a spear through it.

For the finishing touch to this beautiful picture, I chose One Annihilation. I had yet to see anyone take this attack and walk away unscathed.

But then…

“You should’ve picked your opponent more carefully before charging in.”

A low voice like the growl of a beast.

Pung Yang was surrounded by a curtain of qi as red as his eyes. It had completely blocked the vortex unleashed by One Annihilation, and now writhed like living armor.

What did wuxia novels call something like this again?

Oh, right. I remembered. I barely managed to move my lips.

“Body-Protecting Qi?”

“At least you’re not blind.”

“No, for fuck’s sake…”

Sword Energy and Sword Force weren’t enough, and now he had Body-Protecting Qi too?

As I stood there dumbfounded, the sight before my eyes going dark, Pung Yang curled up the corner of his mouth.

“It’s too late for regrets.”

Whoosh!

A strand of saber qi shot up from his curved saber and sliced off a clump of my hair. I had bent at the waist just in time. If I had been even slightly slower, it would have been my head that was cut off.

Fuck.

I swallowed the curse trying to burst out and flung myself away. No sooner had I done so than savage saber strikes shredded the place where I had been standing.

Shh-shh-shh-shhk!

The problem was that every strand of saber qi was unbelievably powerful. The sight of the frozen ground splitting apart like soft tofu sent a chill down my spine.

One wrong move and I’m really going to die.

Even A-rank magic armor wouldn’t have been enough here, yet I was fighting in nothing but a scrap of cloth. This was the very definition of walking on thin ice.

More than anything else…

Doesn’t that bastard ever get tired?

Maintaining Body-Protecting Qi alone had to consume a tremendous amount of internal energy, but right now, Pung Yang seemed like an inexhaustible spring.

“I heard you two were brothers, but the way you run away like rats is exactly the same.”

That was when a voice came from behind him.

“That’s not particularly pleasant to hear.”

Jin Mukyung appeared out of nowhere and scattered a flurry of sword strikes. A streak of blue light shot straight toward Pung Yang’s neck.

Clang!

But even Jin Mukyung's Sword Energy, which seemed capable of cutting through anything, couldn't pierce the Body-Protecting Qi. Pung Yang leisurely rubbed the spot on his neck where the Sword Energy had struck.

"A little stiff. Is that all?"

"Of course not."

Shiiiiing!

As Jin Mukyung charged in without hesitation, the curved saber in Pung Yang's hand moved at the same time. The aura was so powerful that I could feel the flow of the air change.

This wasn't a fight I could interfere in.

Whoosh!

At last, the moment Jin Mukyung's blue Sword Energy met Pung Yang's red saber qi, a tremendous wave of force erupted along with a boom loud enough to make my ears ring.

KABOOM!

Most of the people standing firmly on both feet lost their balance and staggered.

But I widened my eyes and watched the result of this incredible clash.

Which one?

Through the dust swirling from the impact, I saw two people facing each other.

A sword and saber reduced to nothing but their hilts. Tightly pressed lips.

Pung Yang was the first to break the brief silence.

The bastard on his knees spat out dark red blood.

"Urgh—bleeeargh!"

A small cheer rose through the battlefield. Jin Mukyung stood proudly while Pung Yang knelt on the ground. The winner of this fierce battle had been decided.

We won.

I hadn't been able to see the entire exchange, but there was no doubt that Pung Yang had suffered internal injuries first.

The proof was the distinct palm print stamped across his chest—something that hadn't been there before. That had probably been the decisive blow.

"Cough, cough."

Pung Yang wiped the blood from the corner of his mouth and staggered to his feet.

"Striking the Ox Across the Mountain.[706] Even so, I never expected my Body-Protecting Qi to break so easily… Was my enlightenment lacking?"

When Jin Mukyung gave him no answer, Pung Yang clicked his tongue.

[706] A martial-arts term describing force that passes through an intervening defense to strike what lies behind it.

“Damn it. Even after using the Temporary Strength Pill, I’ve ended up like this. I suppose I’ll have to hole up in some remote mountain valley and train my martial arts for a while.”

“A remote mountain valley? Training?”

Genuinely curious, I asked, “Where are you going?”

“Wait, and you’ll find out soon enough. I plan to take you brothers with me, too.”

This was pretty awkward.

Since we’d been invited to a housewarming, should I at least bring a box of tissues?

“Uh, us?”

“Yes. I need the martial arts formulas you know from the Jin Family of Taiyuan. They should be a great help in supplementing the violent qi circulation of the Crimson Blood Cultivation Technique.”

After hearing that much, the words that had been lingering on the tip of my tongue came out on their own.

“Are you, by any chance, a lunatic?”

I hadn’t checked, but everyone probably wore the same expression I did.

The battle had already clearly decided its winner, and yet—what?

“Forget training in some remote mountain valley. I’ll send you on a filial-piety tour of Mount Beimang. You can train there.”[707]

“Mount Beimang? You think you can send me there?”

“Even if it isn’t me personally, there are plenty of people behind you who can send you to Mount Beimang.”

As Pung Yang laughed incredulously, I jerked my chin toward the people behind him.

The martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect were already creeping closer with their weapons drawn.

The beautiful woman among them, glaring at him with especially venomous hatred, had to be the Mount Heng Sword Sect’s new Sect Leader, Lee Seowol.

This man isn’t going to die peacefully.

It was time for him to pay for the karma of his past misdeeds. I flicked my spear toward Pung Yang.

“Still going to keep spouting nonsense?”

The bastard stared at us for a moment before speaking.

“I think you’re laboring under a serious misconception.”

The laugh in his voice was impossible to hide.

“Is there anyone among you capable of defeating me?”

[707] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds and the dead; sending someone there is a euphemism for killing them.

“What the fuck does that even—”

“If you find that hard to believe, it would be faster to ask the Heaven Shaking Sword standing before me. Well? What do you think?”

Jin Mukyung didn’t answer Pung Yang’s question.

Only then did I realize why he hadn’t said a word for some time. Why he had stood there like a stone statue without moving.

Tap.

Pung Yang’s hand touched Jin Mukyung’s chest. At what point had it happened? His unconscious body crumpled limply.

Only then did I see the five throwing knives embedded in a neat row across his upper body.

Thud.

Pung Yang’s red eyes swept across the silent crowd and curved into crescent moons.

“Well, shall we finish things up?”

The “finishing” began quickly.

It started with the more than ten throwing knives that shot from Pung Yang’s sleeve as he approached us at an easy pace.

Whoosh! Thunk-thunk-thunk!

It might have been a close-range attack, but it was a throwing-knife technique that even Jin Mukyung hadn’t been able to evade. Pung Yang’s knives pierced their targets with perfect accuracy, and screams rang out without fail.

“Urgh.”

“Guhk!”

The martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect were already at the limits of their endurance, and none of them were particularly powerful. They were easy prey.

By the time I finally stepped in front of Pung Yang, more than ten of them had already lost their lives.

“Stop.”

He shook his head.

“No. That’s not how it works. Giving orders is a right reserved for the strong.”

“…I’ll kill you.”

“If you were the Heaven Shaking Sword, perhaps. But a wet-behind-the-ears fledgling like you dares?”

I fell silent at Pung Yang’s sneer. He wasn’t wrong. My decision to block his path had been equal parts courage and recklessness.

But how do I take him down?

My mind felt like it was burning itself blank. Amid all the tangled thoughts, two faces surfaced.

The first was the Head Elder. He had been the most powerful and despair-inducing opponent I had ever faced. But back then, I'd had Jin Wikyung and the martial artists of the Jin Family to help me.

What about now?

No one. There was no one.

After taking the Temporary Strength Pill, Pung Yang had to be a master comparable to, or even stronger than, the Head Elder. And the only person left to face him was me.

That naturally brought the second person to mind.

Jopil, One Question, One Kill.

Perhaps Jopil was the person who had forced me to face a genuine crisis. For the first time, I'd lost one of the subordinates I'd gained in the Murim, and I'd nearly died. Only after that had I managed to defeat the bastard.

But the Pung Yang standing before me was on an entirely different level from Jopil.

This goddamn Temporary Strength Pill…

The more I thought about it, the more curses came out. I wanted to see the face of whatever son of a bitch had made it.

"Once you've learned your place, curl up quietly."

Watching Pung Yang act like the greatest master under heaven simply because he trusted that pill twisted my gut. If he'd only been around Jopil's level, I might have found a way to deal with him…

…Wait.

A fact I'd forgotten suddenly flashed through my mind.

There had been something nasty among Jopil's possessions. What was it again?

The Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

A peerless divine elixir that granted half a jiazi of internal energy when consumed—but also a double-edged sword that could kill its user with the fire qi it contained.[708]

The Blazing Flame Divine Pill. The Blazing Flame Divine Pill…

The next moment, I abruptly spoke.

"Hey."

Pung Yang, who had already walked past me, stopped and turned around.

"Hey? Were you talking to me?"

[708] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle; half a jiazi is thirty years.

“Yeah, you pill-popping bastard.”

“Hah. What did this little brat just say…?”

“Did you enjoy being the only one popping pills?”

“…What?”

I looked straight at his face, mottled with bewilderment and fury, and enunciated each word.

“I asked if you enjoyed taking pills all by yourself.”

An eye for an eye. Doping for doping.

Now I was going to pop a pill and fight, too.

You bastard.

Chapter 118

“Was it fun being the only one popping pills?”

“What?”

“I asked if it was fun popping pills all by yourself.”

Pung Yang let out a hollow laugh.

For a mere brat barely twenty, his speech was far too disrespectful. Had being born the youngest young master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and being called the Sleeping Dragon made him think he could get away with anything?

“What a brat. Heh.”

The hollow laughter soon faded, and killing intent filled his eyes.

“Must you see the coffin before you shed tears?”

Jin Taekyung’s eyes widened.

“Wow, that line sounds really weird when you hear it in real life. Say it again.”

“You’re beyond reasoning with.”

As he approached at a leisurely pace, Pung Yang wondered how he could make that young brat beg for his life.

His usual method was to pull out the tongue and slowly break all four limbs. But he couldn’t treat a valuable body that knew the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s martial arts so carelessly.

A reasonable compromise was necessary.

If I sever the sinews and meridians in his legs, he’ll quiet down.

He had already crossed a river of no return with the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Once this fight was over, Pung Yang planned to retreat into some remote mountain valley untouched by human feet, refine his martial arts, and then return to the Murim.

The Red Wind Band had been annihilated, but he could always gather another force. The Murim was ruled by the strong, after all.

“You brought all of this upon yourself, so don’t blame me.”

Pung Yang was just tightening his grip on his curved saber when—

“Ah, wait a second.”

Jin Taekyung held up a hand, then casually tossed something into his mouth.

The action was so natural that Pung Yang couldn’t help stopping.

What is he doing?

His question was answered a moment later.

After Jin Taekyung’s body shuddered once, tremendous heat began to rise from every inch of him.

I had only one option left.

One final gamble with the Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

It was dangerous, but still a hundred times better than dying after Pung Yang forced me to cough up the formulas for the Jin Family's martial arts.

Gulp.

True to its status as a divine elixir, the pill melted the instant it touched my tongue and slid down my throat. The problem began after that.

Ding.

> **System** - You have taken the **Blazing Flame Divine Pill**. - **Circulate your qi** to control its energy.

Hot.

The thirty years of internal energy contained within the Blazing Flame Divine Pill spread through every part of my body like wildfire.

> **System** - You have temporarily gained the **Scorching Yang Qi** attribute. - Your **internal energy** has temporarily increased to 45 years. - If you cannot control the energy, you may die! - Quest, **Divine Pill Absorption**, has been created.

I had no time to check the System notifications chiming incessantly in my ears. I already had my hands full trying to control the Blazing Flame Divine Pill's energy as it rampaged through my body.

"Hoo. Hooooo."

I felt like a human pressure cooker. Smoke curled from my entire body as though I were actually on fire.

The snow beneath my feet melted, and the damp earth softened until it ran like water.

I expected it to some extent, but this is…

It was far beyond anything I'd imagined. I couldn't even scream. All I could do was tremble as Pung Yang's voice cut into my ears.

"What have you done?"

Seeing the bewilderment on his face actually made the heat subside a little.

I forced the corners of my mouth upward.

"What else? I'm going all in."

"You brat!"

Had he sensed something ominous in my answer? Pung Yang's curved saber flew toward me at a blinding speed. A red strand of saber qi extended from the blade and aimed for my chest.

Swish!

Death missed me by exactly half a step. The curved saber missed its target and drew another dizzying arc.

Shh-shh-shh-shhk!

But once again, the blade only cut through empty air. Pung Yang's face twisted as he stared at me, already backed away.

"You…!"

"What, asshole?"

I answered as casually as I could, but no one was more surprised than me. When we'd crossed hands earlier, I hadn't been able to dodge him this easily.

This was on an entirely different level from before, when Pung Yang's overwhelming aura and saber qi had forced me to do nothing but evade.

Since when has my body felt this light?

The instant I thought I needed to avoid an attack, my body moved faster than ever before. And that wasn't the only thing that had changed.

I can see everything clearly.

I could see and read every one of Pung Yang's movements. If I could see his attacks, there was no reason I couldn't evade them. I felt like I could dodge even saber force, let alone saber qi.

At last, I understood why.

It's the internal energy.

My original fifteen years of internal energy had combined with the thirty years from the Blazing Flame Divine Pill. I couldn't control it perfectly, but that didn't mean the power of those thirty years had vanished.

Like an overinflated balloon, the Blazing Flame Divine Pill's energy filled my entire body.

The problem is that I have no idea when this balloon will burst.

So I had to take Pung Yang down before it did.

Feeling the heat bubbling up inside me, I adjusted my grip on the iron spear.

"Come at me."

Pung Yang bit his lip.

"Young brat, you're already getting cocky. Someone like you doesn't stand a chance against me."

"You look pretty tense for someone saying that."

"A wild beast gives its all even when catching a rabbit."

"But a wild beast doesn't take a Temporary Strength Pill to catch a rabbit."

"…!"

Shock flashed across Pung Yang's face. He stared at me with his mouth hanging open, then stammered.

"T-Temporary Strength Pill?"

"Yeah. Temporary Strength Pill."

"How do you know that name?"

"Corporate secret, asshole."

"Did you take one too?"

"Well, I did eat something similar."

I wondered whether he would recognize the name Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

Compared to the Temporary Strength Pill, its stability was complete garbage. As for how powerful its effects were, I intended to find out right now.

"You're fucking dead."

With those final words, I kicked off the ground.

Shweeeeeek!

Pung Yang was deeply troubled.

How does that brat know about the Temporary Strength Pill?

The existence of the Temporary Strength Pill was a secret he had to take to his grave.

It was a hidden trump card that might one day save his life. But if word of it spread, this wondrous object would bring a bloodbath upon the world.

Just the fact that it could draw out two or three times the power of the person who took it would be enough to make martial artists throughout the land salivate and come running.

But there was an even greater problem.

It's a legacy of demonic, heterodox arts.

After the Great Faction War, the Murim had fallen into the hands of the orthodox factions.

If even a rumor spread that Pung Yang had inherited the legacy of demonic, heterodox arts, it wouldn't be only the Jin Family of Taiyuan pursuing him. The entire Murim would come after him.

Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi… I must kill him and eliminate the trouble he'll cause later.

Pung Yang gritted his teeth and unleashed his martial art.

After only a few years of training, he had already attained seventy percent mastery of the Crimson Blood Twelve Sabers. It was more than enough to kill a brat hopelessly beneath him in both age and martial arts.

"Die!"

Shiiing!

The Crimson Blood Twelve Sabers was a domineering martial art. Red saber qi shot from the curved saber and slashed wildly in every direction. The fierce momentum split open the surface of the earth and burst the air apart.

Yet the target it was meant to cut was no longer there.

Jin Taekyung dodged the attack by exactly half a step and thrust his spear.

Shweeeeeek!

The spearhead drove toward Pung Yang's throat. He hastily twisted his head aside to evade it, and a chill ran through his chest.

Fast.

Fast and accurate. Jin Taekyung had yet to reach the stage of injuring others with Sword Energy, the hallmark of a Peak master, but his movements had already caught up to Pung Yang's.

Could this brat have taken the Temporary Strength Pill too? No. It's completely different from mine.

Pung Yang had taken the Temporary Strength Pill several times before.

One look at Jin Taekyung's body, flushed bright red with heat, was enough to tell him that the pill the brat had swallowed wasn't a Temporary Strength Pill.

Then what did he—wait!

Pung Yang couldn't finish the thought. Jin Taekyung had finally seized the initiative and begun unleashing the Jin Family's Spear Technique in earnest.

Shh-shh-shh-shh-shhk!

Dozens of spear shadows poured down like a rain shower. The sight alone was suffocating.

No, it wasn't just an illusion. It really was suffocating.

A bead of sweat rolled down Pung Yang's forehead.

This is…

Scorching Yang Qi.

And not just any Scorching Yang Qi. It was powerful enough to affect even Pung Yang, a Peak master. The Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, had also possessed Scorching Yang Qi, but it couldn't compare to what Jin Taekyung was emitting now.

He took a divine elixir—a Scorching Yang-type divine elixir!

Whoooooom!

Recognizing it changed nothing. The heat was dizzying, and the attacks were sharp. Pung Yang bit down hard on his lip as he retreated again and again, barely evading the spearhead.

Against a brat this young!

He had lived his entire life fiercely. Now, even after taking the Temporary Strength Pill, he felt humiliated to be driven back by a young brat who had only just begun making a name for himself.

That anger flowed straight into his curved saber. The saber qi rising over the blade blazed redder than ever.

Hiss!

The Jin Family's Spear Technique and the Crimson Blood Twelve Sabers differed in both weapon and form, but they had one thing in common: both were domineering martial arts.

In the blink of an eye, Jin Taekyung's iron spear and Pung Yang's curved saber finally parted after more than ten fierce exchanges.

"Hmm."

Jin Taekyung was the first to retreat. Blood flowed from his torn palm, and the heavy, sturdy iron spear had been cut by the sharp saber qi until less than half of it remained.

"You fool."

Pung Yang smiled triumphantly. For a martial artist, losing one's weapon meant defeat.

Even the Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, who had built his reputation with nothing but his fists and feet, had knelt before Pung Yang. Jin Taekyung hadn't even crossed the wall into the Peak realm. The moment he lost his weapon, he was as good as dead.

"Did you think you could defeat me head-on?"

Jin Taekyung wiped the blood from his palm and answered.

"No. But I did learn some valuable information."

"…Valuable information?"

"Yeah. I figured out your attack pattern."

"Pat—what?"

"Your attack pattern is strong, strong, strong, strong, strong."

What kind of bullshit is this?

Pung Yang understood that the brat was talking about his martial arts, but he had never heard of this "pattern-whatever" before. And what did he mean by strong, strong, strong, strong, strong?

Pung Yang glared at Jin Taekyung with murder in his eyes.

“I’ll sever the sinews and meridians in all four of your limbs as payment for that nonsense.”

Jin Taekyung opened his mouth with a bored expression.

“You really like cutting off limbs and pulling out tongues. Do you have a limb fetish?”

“You little bastard…”

“You old bastard…”

Pung Yang drew a deep breath. He was a Peak master who had spent his entire life possessing a cool, rational mind. But he couldn’t stop his voice from breaking into pieces with anger.

“You. Will. Die. By. My. Hand.”

“I. Sometimes. Cut off. Limbs. Sometimes. I don’t like this version of myself.”

He felt his patience snap. He could swear that he had never been this furious in nearly ten years.

“Graaaargh!”

Pung Yang charged like a madman, unleashing a strange cry that could have been either a scream or a roar.

Without using any form or martial art, he brought the curved saber down over the crown of Jin Taekyung’s head with all his strength.

“Die!”

That was when Jin Taekyung’s calm expression was reflected in Pung Yang’s bloodshot eyes gleaming with killing intent.

In an instant, his mind snapped clear as though someone had dumped cold water over him.

Something’s wrong.

Pung Yang drew up his internal energy with all his might.

As his Body-Protecting Qi rose, a dagger flashed in Jin Taekyung’s previously empty hand.

Shnk!

Chapter 119

Shnk!

A sharp tingle ran through my fingertips—a familiar sensation I'd felt thousands, even tens of thousands of times before.

It went in.

The instant I was certain, I twisted the dagger buried in Pung Yang's side. A scream burst from his mouth.

"Graaaargh!"

The dagger itself must have hurt like hell, but the strike had also inflicted a serious internal injury. His Body-Protecting Qi scattered like smoke before it could fully form, proving as much.

That was close.

Pung Yang's instincts were no joke. If the dagger hadn't pierced him in that split second before his Body-Protecting Qi formed, I would have been the one in trouble.

"Guh!"

Pung Yang spat out dark blood and reached out with one arm. In that instant, a flash of light burst from inside his pitch-black sleeve.

Shweeeeeek!

I instantly stepped back and tilted my head back. A throwing knife shot from Pung Yang's sleeve and narrowly grazed the bridge of my nose.

That was dangerous.

If I hadn't stepped back, it would have struck my throat instead of my nose.

I'd only managed to dodge because I'd already seen Pung Yang use throwing knives. I stuck out my tongue and licked up the blood trickling down my nose.

"Thanks. I was thirsty anyway."

"You little rat bastard…!"

Pung Yang backed away and ground his teeth.

"Was this your plan from the beginning?"

"Yeah. Hurts, doesn't it?"

"Just wait. I'll pay you back a hundredfold."

"There's no need to go that far between friends. You can keep it."

"Grrrrrgh!"

Teasing him was surprisingly satisfying. It would have been nice if he dropped dead from rage, but I doubted I'd get that lucky.

It was a good opportunity.

I'd succeeded in drawing Pung Yang in with Taunt, but I'd failed to finish him off. Even after taking the Blazing Flame Divine Pill, there was still a huge gap between us.

And more importantly—

This is getting rough.

My entire body was hot as a furnace. The thirty years of Scorching Yang Qi that I hadn't been able to control from the beginning was now running wild of its own accord.

It would have been touch and go even if I'd tried to suppress it with my existing internal energy, but I'd fought Pung Yang at close quarters with the reins completely off, and my condition was steadily worsening.

Damn it. I wish it had been a Temporary Strength Pill instead of the Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

The two pills had been created for entirely different purposes.

Was the Temporary Strength Pill a stimulant that temporarily awakened latent power and raised it to its limit? To put it simply, the difference was like that between traditional herbal medicine and a stimulant.

Does that bastard not have any side effects? He's still disgustingly lively.

I was looking at Pung Yang with a trace of envy when—

"Cough."

Oh? What was this?

As Pung Yang coughed, the whites of his eyes showed for an instant.

His eyes had been completely blood-red the entire time. No matter how I thought about it, there could only be one reason for this change.

The Temporary Strength Pill is wearing off.

Pung Yang was flustered. He immediately recognized the abnormal signs appearing in his body.

Already?

The Temporary Strength Pill's effect lasted a little over one shichen.[709] Yet now, after barely half a shichen[710] had passed, the power that had been surging through his entire body was gradually fading.

Fatigue he hadn't felt before pressed heavily down on his shoulders, and pain that had seemed distant began to prick at his nerves.

"Cough."

On top of that, he had suffered a considerable internal injury.

[709] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[710] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Pung Yang bit his lip at the dark-red blood mixed into his cough.

I've expended too much strength.

The Temporary Strength Pill was a wondrous object that could draw out twice, or even more than twice, the strength a person possessed—but it demanded an equal price.

In exchange for temporarily granting tremendous power, it weakened the body's physical abilities. If the user's body could not support it, the effect would disappear.

Taking Temporary Strength Pills back-to-back was the problem.

First the Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, and then these young brats from the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Without the pills, Pung Yang would have died long ago, but he knew their price and feared the backlash.

At this rate, the effects will last no more than one meal's time…[711]

He had to settle the battle within that time.

He must not use the last Temporary Strength Pill. Taking three in succession could put his life at risk.

"One meal's time…"[712]

Pung Yang muttered under his breath and glared at the remaining prey.

"That's more than enough."

The flash of white vanished as his eyes filled with blood-red light once more.

Had I imagined it?

When Pung Yang raised his head again, his eyes were red, and an overwhelming aura poured from his entire body.

"I'll kill you with a single stroke."

I watched his curved saber and opened my mouth.

"I thought you needed the martial arts formulas."

"It doesn't have to be you. Why do you think I went to the trouble of keeping Jin Mukyung alive?"

"Because you love him."

"I swear by the gods of heaven and earth… I will cut out your tongue."

Pung Yang raised his curved saber.

Shweeeeeek! Clang!

He caught the iron arrow that came flying at him with tremendous force and frowned.

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[711] "One meal's time" renders *sikgyeong*, a traditional expression for approximately half an hour.

[712] "One meal's time" renders *sikgyeong*, a traditional expression for approximately half an hour.

“There’s no shortage of bastards eager to die. No, is it a bitch this time?”

The owner of the arrow slowly walked over and stood beside me. Her footsteps were light as down, and the top of her head barely reached my shoulder. Even in this desperate situation, her beauty was enough to steal my gaze for an instant.

Lee Seowol, Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, whispered to me.

“We’ll buy you some time.”

By *we*, she meant herself and the surviving martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

There were only ten of them. Every one was a First Rate master, as one might expect of those who had survived such a brutal battle to the bitter end. But against Pung Yang, the outcome was obvious.

They’ll be wiped out.

How much time could they buy even if they stepped forward? They were more likely to get in my way. It was coldhearted, but that was reality.

I shook my head.

“That won’t change anything.”

“We’re not saying we’ll fight alongside you.”

“Then?”

“Take your brother and run.”

Pung Yang stood only a little over ten zhang[713]—about thirty meters[714]—away. No matter how quietly she spoke, there was no way a Peak master like him hadn’t heard her.

“What, run? Hahahaha!”

Lee Seowol ignored his booming laughter and continued.

“It may only be for a fleeting moment, but we’ll buy you time. Run as far away as you can.”

I looked toward the fortress gate. It was about one hundred zhang[715]—three hundred meters[716]—from here. Just beyond it were Wolhwa, Hyuk Mujin, and the horses waiting to carry us away.

It’s worth a try.

I was already suffering internal injuries from the Blazing Flame Divine Pill, but I could still endure them to some extent. If I squeezed out every last bit of strength I had, I might be able to escape even while carrying Jin Mukyung on my back.

But…

They’ll die.

Every last one of them. Not a single exception.

---

[713] A zhang is a traditional Chinese length of approximately 3 meters, or 9.8 ft.
[714] Thirty meters is about 98 ft.
[715] A zhang is a traditional Chinese length of approximately 3 meters, or 9.8 ft.
[716] Three hundred meters is about 980 ft.

Lee Seowol herself was included in that *we*. She had stepped forward prepared to die as well.

Why?

The Mount Heng Sword Sect and the Jin Family of Taiyuan were bitter enemies. Even if they had been manipulated by the Head Elder's schemes, they had killed one another, and both sides had shed a great deal of blood.

And yet Lee Seowol was trying to save me.

Even if it meant sacrificing her life and the lives of her subordinates.

"You don't need to look at us like that. I reached this conclusion after careful consideration. In return, may I ask you for one thing?"

I asked her,

"What is it?"

"Avenge us in our place."

Lee Seowol stared coldly at Pung Yang.

"Kill that bastard. As cruelly as possible."

Ten people were throwing away their lives for one person's death.

I could feel the hatred Lee Seowol held in every word. As I stood there speechless, Pung Yang, who had been watching us with a mocking smile, opened his mouth.

"You've come up with quite the bold idea, but it won't happen. You'll all bury your bones here."

One of the Mount Heng martial artists shouted.

"Shut up, you vicious bastard!"

Thwack!

The next instant, the martial artist's head snapped back. The iron arrow Pung Yang had been holding was embedded in his forehead.

"Senior Brother!"

As the belated scream rang out, Pung Yang smiled.

"I was just about out of throwing knives… Thank you, Sect Leader."

Lee Seowol bit her lip.

"Go! Hurry!"

I took a deep breath. I had already mapped out every step in my head.

Jin Mukyung lay only about twenty zhang[717]—sixty meters[718]—away. If I drew up as much internal energy as possible and ran with him on my back, enduring the internal injuries, I could reach the fortress gate in no time.

Pung Yang might catch up by then, but if they bought me just a little more time, I could survive.

I can go back.

[717] A zhang is a traditional Chinese length of approximately 3 meters, or 9.8 ft.
[718] Sixty meters is about 200 ft.

Back to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, where Jin Wikyung was. Back home, where my mother and Hayeon were waiting.

If I lived to fight another day, I was confident I could return far stronger—strong enough to make Pung Yang look insignificant.

That's enough.

I drew another deep breath and turned toward Lee Seowol.

"I'll avenge you. I swear."

For the briefest instant, I thought she smiled.

Perhaps I imagined it. The moment passed too quickly, and when I looked again, only firm resolve remained on her face.

"Go. Hurry."

Her words were the starting signal. The Mount Heng martial artists charged with furious shouts, Lee Seowol at the front.

Yes. I have to go.

I drew up every last bit of internal energy in my body. Sharp pain tore through me as the internal injuries left by the Scorching Yang Qi sent dark-red blood flowing from my nose, but I endured it.

It only had to last a moment. A very brief moment.

Inventory open. Equip spear.

The cool shaft settled into my grip.

Then I pushed off the ground once.

Boom.

I shot forward like an arrow—no, faster than an arrow.

Not toward Jin Mukyung.

Toward Pung Yang.

I could see his broad smile.

"That's more like it!"

"Shut up, you son of a bitch."

"Ha-ha-ha-ha!"

Pung Yang's curved saber was larger than ever before. Brimming with red saber qi, it swung toward me.

Whoooosh!

The wind exploded, and even the air seemed to vanish.

I gripped the iron spear hard enough to crush it.

Please. Just this once.

I poured all fifteen years of my internal energy into the spear. Drawing my shoulder and waist as far back as they would go, I sent everything I had flying forward.

One Annihilation.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The immense saber qi collided with the vortex.

A thunderous roar filled the world, as though the sky itself were splitting apart. Through the raging wind, I saw it clearly.

Kaboom!

The white vortex shattered into pieces before the red saber qi. The massive concentration of qi completely pulverized One Annihilation.

Pung Yang whispered with an ecstatic expression,

“This is as far as you go.”

The next instant, Pung Yang’s internal energy surged along the spear and slammed into me.

Boom!

Blinding pain and ringing ears rolled over me like waves.

Ding.

> **System** - You have suffered **Internal Injury**! Your condition is extremely serious! - **Scorching Yang Qi** is running wild! - You have suffered a **Severe Injury**! All stats have dropped significantly!

The System notifications rang out one after another, mingling with the Mount Heng martial artists’ shouts, Lee Seowol’s scream, and Pung Yang’s laughter.

It’s over.

The instant my legs gave out despite my will, a powerful hand clamped around my throat.

“Guh. Guhh.”

“That was fairly impressive. If I’d been even a moment slower, you might have won.”

Pung Yang bared his teeth in a grin. The red light in his eyes was slowly fading.

Damn it. I was so damn close.

I wanted to say it aloud, but my mouth was full of blood, making even that difficult.

“I swore by the gods of heaven and earth, didn’t I? I swore I’d pull out your tongue.”

Had he said that? By now, I could barely remember who I was.

Pung Yang pried open my mouth with his other hand. His rough fingers seized my blood-soaked tongue and pulled.

“Ghh…”

“When you were running that mouth, didn’t you know this would happen? Huh?”

“Ghaa… hahahaa.”

“Hahaha! What the hell are you babbling about? Shall I let you say your last words?”

Pung Yang laughed heartily and released my tongue. Only then could I speak. I swallowed the blood in my mouth and said,

“Salty.”

“What?”

“Damn salty.”

“What kind of bullshit is that?”

What do you think?

I’m saying the taste of your fingers brought me back to my senses a little.

Half-conscious, I muttered,

Inventory open. Summon anything.

Ding.

> **System** - No item named **Anything** can be found. The oldest item stored in your inventory will be summoned first. - The **Unnamed Sword** has been summoned.

The Unnamed Sword? What was that again?

Whatever.

I gathered the last of my strength and thrust the sword in my hand at Pung Yang’s chest, shrouded in Body-Protecting Qi.

It was a futile last-ditch attack with an obvious conclusion.

Damn Body-Protecting Qi.

But this was enough.

I had no regrets left.

It was at that moment, as my head slowly drooped—

Shnk!

Ding.

> **System** - The **Unnamed Sword** has satisfied a specific condition. - **Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron** has destroyed **Body-Protecting Qi**.

…Huh?

Chapter 120

Shwick!

A sword thrust forward—slowly, but with tremendous force.

For the briefest moment, a mocking smile appeared at the corner of Pung Yang's mouth.

I knew this was coming.

He had spent decades living in Gaoyuan, where every kind of underhanded trick ran rampant. If he had been foolish enough to fall for the same trick twice, he would have become wild-dog food long ago.

But where did that sword come from?

It wasn't a dagger. Where had the brat hidden a longsword that size?

With that slight question in mind, Pung Yang drew up his Body-Protecting Qi.

Fssssss.

He had expected this, so his response was quick. Red qi surged up in an instant and wrapped tightly around his body.

Body-Protecting Qi was invincible armor that nothing short of powerful Sword Energy could so much as scratch. The young brat's futile struggle was laughable.

What an annoying bastard. Just die already.

He was about to snap Jin Taekyung's neck in a single motion when—

Thud!

"…Huh?"

A cold chill pierced his body, followed by searing pain. Pung Yang stared wide-eyed at the sword that had pierced straight through his chest.

What the hell?

His Body-Protecting Qi had vanished.

No—it had been destroyed.

Jin Taekyung's sword sliced through it as easily as cutting tofu, then pierced Pung Yang's chest as well.

Pung Yang looked down at the transparent blade, unstained by even a drop of blood, and muttered like he was groaning.

"Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron…?"

He had heard of it before. Stories about a divine weapon said to be capable of cutting and breaking anything in the world.

"How did you get this?"

Pung Yang glared at the sword's owner with a twisted expression. The young brat from the Jin Family of Taiyuan blinked innocently.

"Wow. This actually worked."

"You fucking bastard…!"

He wanted to snap the brat's neck right away, but his vision suddenly went hazy, and the strength drained from his grip. The power that had filled his body vanished like the outgoing tide, leaving only helplessness in its wake.

The Temporary Strength Pill had to wear off now of all times.

Blood streamed from the seven openings in Pung Yang's face as he staggered backward.

The injuries he had suffered, both great and small, combined with the dispersal of his Body-Protecting Qi. The internal energy surging backward through his body began driving him rapidly toward death.

I can't die like this. I can't.

Pung Yang hurriedly searched inside his robes.

He still had one Temporary Strength Pill left. If he took it, he could beat these bastards to death in a single stroke and leave this place. He had lost plenty, but he could recover and return to Murim afterward.

Yes. All he had to do was take the Temporary Strength Pill…

Clatter.

Damn it. He was in too much of a hurry.

The wooden box slipped from Pung Yang's frantic hand, struck the ground, and sprang open. A pill tinged with a blood-red color rolled across the ground before coming to a stop beneath someone's foot.

"Oh, so this is the Temporary Strength Pill?"

Jin Taekyung picked it up and examined it curiously. Pung Yang shouted at him.

"G-Give it to me! Hurry!"

"Here's a question. Do you really think I'll give it to you just because you ask?"

"You bastard!"

Pung Yang lunged forward with all his remaining strength, but his ruined body had already reached its limit. His legs gave out before he could reach Jin Taekyung, and he crumpled to the ground.

Only one path remained to Pung Yang now.

"Please. I'm begging you. Give it to me. Give it to me!"

"What if I do?"

Pung Yang cried out desperately.

"You'll never see me again. No—I'll swear my loyalty to you from this day forward!"

"Oh, a Peak master as my subordinate. That sounds pretty good."

"R-Really? Then hurry and give me the Temporary Strength Pill!"

"First, I'm taking my property back."

"Your property?"

His question was answered a moment later when Jin Taekyung approached and yanked the sword from the center of his chest.

Blood poured out like a waterfall, accompanied by dizzying pain.

“Gueeeeegh!”

Pung Yang didn’t even notice the pieces of internal organs mixed with the blood he vomited.

All he felt was his vision gradually darkening and the sounds around him receding into the distance.

He was dying, and desperation had driven him half-mad.

I want to live.

Pung Yang had spent his entire life as a ruthless marauder.

He had stolen the wealth—and sometimes the lives—of countless people, but never in his wildest dreams had he imagined meeting an end like this.

“Now… now, please give me the Temporary Strength Pill…”

Through his blurred vision, he saw Jin Taekyung shake his head. Pung Yang mumbled piteously.

“Why? Why not?”

But the answer came from somewhere else.

“What? Why?”

“That bastard deserves to be torn limb from limb!”

The surviving martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect gripped their weapons, their eyes brimming with killing intent.

Lee Seowol also bit her lip and aimed her bow at Pung Yang, but Jin Taekyung hurriedly stopped her.

“Let’s hold off on the finishing blow… No, he’s too vicious to let him die comfortably. Better to leave him there and let him die slowly.”

Lee Seowol wrestled with the decision for a moment before finally lowering her bow. Jin Taekyung approached Pung Yang and whispered into his ear.

“I’m starting to get tired too. Let’s just die now.”

Pung Yang didn’t understand what he meant, but one thing was certain.

Death.

Pung Yang realized that his own death was almost upon him.

“Even if I become a vengeful ghost, I’ll have my revenge.”

“Amen. In your next life, be satisfied with Viagra.”

Pung Yang gave a hollow laugh. It was absurd that he had to listen to that bastard’s incomprehensible nonsense until the very end.

Damn it. What terrible weather.

He raised his head and looked at the sky. It was entirely red.

Then darkness swallowed it.

As Pung Yang's head lolled to the side, celebratory fireworks burst overhead.
Ding. Ding. Ding!

> **System** - Defeated **Lv. 85 Pung Yang**! - Successfully completed the **Temporary Strength Pill** Quest! - Obtained a massive amount of **EXP** and **Fame**! - Level Up! - Level Up! - ...

After announcing five level-ups and an increase in Fame, the System window delivered even better news.

> **System** - The Quest success reward has been delivered to your **Inventory**! - **Full Recovery** has taken effect immediately as the Quest success reward!

Full Recovery?
It said the effect would be immediate, and the change happened exactly as promised.
Cracked and broken bones knitted together. Cuts and puncture wounds healed without a trace. And the changes didn't stop at the surface.
My Internal Injuries...
Invisible healing took place inside my body as well. I had expected all my Internal Injuries to heal, but there was an even greater benefit than I had imagined.

> **System** - All **Internal Injuries** have healed! - Your stabilized body accepts new qi! - The **Blazing Flame Divine Pill** has been fully absorbed! - Your **internal energy** has risen to 45 years! - Your **internal energy** has gained the **Scorching Yang Qi** attribute!

The Blazing Flame Divine Pill had been completely absorbed.
And my internal energy had risen dramatically.
I could feel power filling every limb and bone. The Scorching Yang Qi that had burned through my body like lava had somehow become a warm spring breeze.
I did it.
I had planned to circulate my qi and control the Scorching Yang Qi once my body recovered somewhat from the level-ups, but thanks to the System, I had handled the difficult part with ease.
Forty-five years? Just how much is that?

It was three times what I'd originally possessed—an increase of half a jiazi, a full thirty years of internal energy.

Half a jiazi.

Under normal circumstances, I would have put off taking the Blazing Flame Divine Pill. But the gamble had turned out to be a masterstroke.

I would have died if luck hadn't been on my side, though.

Two strokes of heavenly luck.

One was the Blazing Flame Divine Pill. The other was the **Unnamed Sword** in my hand.

Both were loot I had obtained after defeating Jopil several months ago.

Without this, I really would've been screwed.

I'd thought it was merely a little sharper and harder than other swords. Never in my wildest dreams had I imagined it was actually Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron—or that it had such an ability.

In that sense, *seven parts luck and three parts skill* didn't suit me today. *Nine parts luck and one part qi* was much more appropriate.

Though I'm not sure this really counts as good luck.

I slowly looked around.

A graveyard of weapons stood with their hilts buried in the ground. Some people had died with their faces planted in pools of blood. Others stared wide-eyed at the sky as dawn began to break.

There were hundreds of corpses like that.

"There's a survivor here!"

"Chunsam! Wake up!"

Amid that horrific scene, the martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect moved tirelessly. As I watched them rescue the few survivors with disciplined efficiency, I was suddenly seized by an inexplicable sense of wrongness.

What is it?

It felt like I'd forgotten something important…

Just as I was frowning, one of the corpses that had been lying motionless sat up.

"Guuuuuh."

"Oh."

Right. Good to see you, Mukyung.

By the time the two-shichen[719] search was over, Lee Seowol was soaked in blood.

"How many survivors?"

[719] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

“Twenty-five, including you, Sect Leader.”

“How many did you say?”

“Twenty-five. Five of them probably won’t make it through today.”

Both Lee Seowol, who had asked the question, and the martial artist who answered it fell silent.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect, which had once divided Shanxi Province with the Jin Family of Taiyuan, no longer existed. All that remained were the wounded and a young Sect Leader who wasn’t even twenty years old.

If I had abandoned this place and fled, if I had accepted Pung Yang’s marriage proposal from the beginning, could I have saved them?

Regret was always futile.

But Lee Seowol had to regret.

Although few remained, she was still the Sect Leader of a sect. Only by agonizing over her mistakes and regretting them to the bone could she avoid making the same mistakes again.

That was her atonement to those who had died today and her effort on behalf of those who remained.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect will survive. If only for those who gave their lives for our sect.

Lee Seowol clenched her fist. Her fingernails, broken from drawing the bowstring, dug into her flesh. Blood seeped out, but she felt no pain.

“What about the others?”

“They’re all in the main hall. A woman from the Jin Family of Taiyuan knows a fair amount about medicine and is treating the wounded, but…”

The martial artist’s expression darkened. It was proof of just how bad the condition of some of the wounded was.

Lee Seowol asked no more questions and headed toward the main hall.

We haven’t even had time to collect ourselves, and already I’m sending them off again.

Unbearable fatigue pressed down on her entire body, but she held on through sheer willpower.

At the very least, she had to be there for their final moments.

Creeeeak.

When Lee Seowol entered the main hall, the people from the Jin Family of Taiyuan were nowhere in sight. The wounded lying on the floor immediately caught her eye.

The Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, and more than a dozen martial artists noticed her and called out.

“Ah, Seowol. You’ve come?”

“You’re here, Sect Leader!”

“We greet you, Sect Leader!”

“…?”

Was it just her imagination?

For people on the verge of death, they seemed strangely full of energy. After staring at them in silence for a while, Lee Seowol realized what that energy meant.

“A final rally…”

Only then did she see the dark shadow of death hanging over their faces.

Just as she hurriedly turned away to hold back her tears—

Bang!

Lee Seowol staggered after striking her forehead against something solid. As she began to fall, a large, firm hand caught her by the shoulder.

“Oh, careful there. Are you all right?”

“Ah, yes.”

“Then we’re good.”

Jin Taekyung looked down at Lee Seowol and let out a short laugh.

Some final rally.

I barely held back a snort.

Cheol Mubaek and the other wounded were all recovering vigorously.

Of course, Jin Mukyung was no exception.

What would they have done without me?

More precisely, if not for the Quest rewards, half of them might have needed funerals.

The thirty **Superior Wound Medicines** and thirty **Ten-Year He Shouwu**[720] I’d received as rewards were remarkably effective at treating external wounds and Internal Injuries.

I did consider saving them for an emergency…

But I wasn’t heartless enough to ignore people dying right in front of me.

Of course, the sheer quantity had played a part too.

“Aren’t you coming in?”

“What?”

“If you’re not going in, I’ll go in first.”

I was about to walk past Lee Seowol, who was standing there in a daze, when I suddenly remembered what I’d forgotten.

Wait. Where did I put that?

[720] *He Shouwu* is the root of Chinese knotweed, used in traditional Chinese medicine.

“Ah, here it is.”

I pretended to rummage through my robes and pulled a bamboo slip[721] from my Inventory.

“Here. It’s from my hyung[722]… no, from the Lesser Family Head.”

Lee Seowol accepted the bamboo slip[723] with a bewildered expression.

The instant she took it, a System notification rang out.

Ding.

> **System** - Invitation delivery complete. - Quest **Yesterday’s Enemy, Today’s Ally** completed!

Invitation delivery.

If I had to do that twice, someone was going to die.

[721] A bamboo slip is a strip of bamboo used as a writing surface.
[722] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older male.
[723] A bamboo slip is a strip of bamboo used as a writing surface.

Chapter 121

It had been a fierce battle—fierce enough to leave mountains of corpses and rivers of blood—yet most of the Mount Heng Sword Sect's buildings remained largely intact.

Like this pavilion, for instance.

I collapsed into a chair and leaned back.

"Ugh. I'm dying."

Exhaustion always followed a major battle like the one we had just fought.

Leveling up could restore my physical fatigue, but it couldn't do anything about mental fatigue.

And after skirting the brink of death like I had today, it was even worse.

That was seriously dangerous.

Jopil. The Head Elder. Pung Yang.

Nothing good had ever come from getting tangled up with Peak masters. More than once, I'd found myself wishing I had about five lives.

"Squad Leader, thank you for your hard work."

"Yeah, yeah."

"Whew, your shoulders are really tense."

Hyuk Mujin sidled up and began massaging my shoulders.

Wolhwa and Hyuk Mujin had been protecting Cheol Mubaek outside before joining the survivor search once things had more or less settled down.

"If I'd been there, I would've really laid into that bastard Pung Yang. You know what I mean, right?"

"Of course. You would've gotten yourself killed on the spot."

"…"

"What? Come on, massage a little harder."

Hyuk Mujin grumbled, but he put more strength into his hands and kneaded my shoulders.

"What about Jin Mukyung? I mean, my second brother?"

"We've already moved him elsewhere. The physicians said there's no need to worry. They also said the other wounded are recovering quickly."

"Really? That's a relief."

"Aren't they quacks? I heard the Second Young Master and Great Hero Cheol Mubaek both suffered fairly serious Internal Injuries."

"They were sent by the Lower District Sect. Let's trust their skills."

In truth, it wasn't the physicians I trusted. It was the efficacy of the Items.

If not for the **Superior Wound Medicine**, which could heal most wounds within a few days, and the **Ten-Year He Shouwu**[724], which was exceptionally effective at treating Internal Injuries, some of them would already have crossed the River Jordan[725].

I've given them the minimum emergency treatment. The physicians can take care of the rest.

The Lower District Sect—or rather, Wolhwa—had moved quickly without any of us realizing it. Several days ago, when she sent one of her subordinates back from the shrine, she had apparently issued a mobilization order to a nearby branch.

The Lower District Sect's support force arrived half a day after the battle ended and immediately began dealing with the aftermath.

While everyone else was looking ahead, she was thinking about what came after.

The Lower District Sect's support force had been organized for relief work, not combat.

They had brought physicians, cooks, and even laborers. Their foresight and preparation were enough to make me marvel.

She really isn't an ordinary person.

The Lower District Sect was both an information organization found throughout the land and a Murim sect.

Wolhwa had become a Branch Leader in a sect of that size while still in her mid-to-late twenties. There was no way she was ordinary.

Come to think of it, Wolhwa isn't even her real name.

The name I'd discovered through Qi Sense was Eun Sowol. As for why she had gone out of her way to hide it from us, I figured it was something like using a code name in a spy movie.

One thing was certain: making an enemy of someone that capable would be exhausting.

Don't get too close. Keep a reasonable distance and maintain proper boundaries. Yeah, that should be about right.

Fortunately, that wouldn't be too difficult. Wolhwa had shown me inexplicable goodwill and curiosity from the very beginning.

Whether those were genuine feelings or simply the curiosity of a veteran information merchant was something I would have to watch a little longer to determine.

"Mujin-ah."[726]

"Should I massage harder?"

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[724] He shouwu is a plant used in traditional Chinese herbal medicine.

[725] In Korean speech, crossing the Jordan River is a way of saying someone has died.

[726] The Korean suffix *-ah* is an informal way to address someone by name, typically someone familiar or younger.

“No, not that. What do you think of Young Lady Wolhwa?”

“She’s pretty.”

“And?”

Hyuk Mujin thought hard before answering.

“She’s extremely pretty.”

“…”

“Massage my forearms instead of my shoulders.”

I was the idiot for asking that guy anything.

Hyuk Mujin looked wounded and was about to retort when light footsteps slowly approached and stopped in front of the door.

Wolhwa?

No. The qi I sensed outside the door was far weaker and smaller than Wolhwa’s.

After a brief silence, an unexpected guest spoke.

“Young Master Jin, may I come in?”

The voice was clear and distinct.

It was Lee Seowol.

Once Hyuk Mujin left the pavilion, Lee Seowol and I were alone.

I gazed out the window at the slowly darkening sky and cleared my throat for no reason.

“Ahem. Ahem.”

Being alone with a woman at this hour—especially a stunning beauty—was a trial in itself.

Worse yet, she was the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, whom we had been fighting like sworn enemies until recently.

They said new wine belonged in new wineskins, but she was the only daughter of Lee Cheonbaek, the man who had tried to bring down the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and she and I were already entangled in a scandal.

What the hell am I supposed to say?

May the deceased rest in peace?

No. That would make the atmosphere far too heavy. As if losing her family recently hadn’t been enough, she had also lost most of her subordinates in the battle against Pung Yang.

After agonizing over it, I finally opened my mouth.

“Have you eaten?”

“…”

“I know you’ve been through something difficult, but it’s even more important to keep your strength up at times like this, so… Sorry.”

Damn it. I should’ve just kept my mouth shut.

As I was regretting my words from the bottom of my heart, Lee Seowol rose from her seat and bowed deeply to me.

“Lee Seowol of the Mount Heng Sword Sect pays her respects to her benefactor.”

It happened before I could stop her. Flustered, I hurriedly helped her to her feet.

Benefactor?

It was accurate, but hearing it made me cringe.

“Oh, come on. What are you doing? You don’t have to call me your benefactor.”

“No. A person ought to receive kindness and know how to be grateful for it. Please do not make me feel ashamed, Benefactor.”

Her tone was so resolute that I couldn’t stop her anymore.

She’s not wrong.

If not for Jin Mukyung and me, the Mount Heng Sword Sect would have shut its doors today. A deep bow wasn’t enough. They could have erected statues of us and it still wouldn’t have been sufficient.

Maybe they could designate today as the Day the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi Came and make it an annual Mount Heng Sword Sect holiday—

That might be taking things too far. Anyway.

“Now, calm down and sit.”

“I will follow my benefactor’s instructions.”

“Could you stop calling me that?”

“Yes, Benefactor.”

This is driving me crazy.

Only after Lee Seowol answered with a calm expression and sat down was I finally able to hear why she had come to see me.

“I came to give you my answer regarding the letter.”

“The letter? Oh.”

She meant the invitation.

The polite invitation to have a meal at the Jin Family of Taiyuan on New Year’s Day, which was fast approaching—a summons disguised as a dinner invitation.

Now that the Jin Family of Taiyuan had Shanxi Murim firmly in its grasp, it was obvious that any sect refusing the invitation would face an unpleasant future.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect, which had only narrowly escaped annihilation, was no exception.

“So what’s your answer?”

“We will gladly accept your sect’s proposal.”

It was the answer I had expected.

But Lee Seowol didn't stop there. She continued speaking.

"Furthermore, as an apology for what happened, I will transfer every right held by our sect to the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Rights?"

"Yes. All rights to the territory currently occupied by our sect."

In other words, she was saying that she would hand over all of northern Shanxi to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

She's going this far?

The fact that the Mount Heng Sword Sect had bowed its head to the Jin Family of Taiyuan was already a given. Jin Wikyung would demand a great deal in compensation, but even he couldn't completely swallow the sect whole.

Wolhwa had said something similar during our previous conversation.

And now she's serving it up to us without even being asked.

After calling me her benefactor over and over, it seemed she hadn't just been paying lip service.

Right. Gratitude shouldn't end with words. Hm.

"Thank you. My eldest brother will be pleased."

"There's more."

What? She isn't finished yet?

Lee Seowol took three books from inside her robes and held them out to me.

I slowly read the titles on their covers.

"Blood Wolf Sword Technique, Blood Wolf Footwork. And…"

"Shura Annihilating Fist. The sword technique and footwork technique were created by my father himself. The Shura Annihilating Fist is Uncle Cheol's secret ultimate technique. Every one of them is an outstanding Peak martial art."

"Peak martial arts…"

I swallowed hard.

One of the things I had learned painfully in the Murim was the importance of martial arts. Even I was barely able to make up for my deficiencies by relying on the System. For ordinary martial artists, it went without saying.

To them, an outstanding Peak martial art was a priceless treasure.

These are worth more than the rights to northern Shanxi.

If those rights were the branches of a tree, the three martial arts manuals before me were its roots.

Lee Seowol had placed her father's legacy—the most valuable possessions of the Mount Heng Sword Sect—on the scales.

"Is this a gift too?"

"No. This is a transaction."

I knew it.

A transaction.

If it was Jin Wikyung, he would accept the deal by any means necessary. Three Peak martial arts were at stake, after all.

What on earth is she going to demand?

Wealth? A guarantee of safety? Or something else?

Lee Seowol—or rather, the Mount Heng Sword Sect—was in a situation beyond desperate. Even if they were offering their martial arts at a bargain price, whatever they wanted in return was certain to be a difficult demand.

I cautiously distanced myself from the matter.

“I’m curious what kind of transaction this is, but I don’t know if you’re aware—I don’t have that kind of authority.”

Lee Seowol gazed steadily at me with eyes as clear as a lake.

“Is that so?”

“Yes. I don’t have a particular position, either. I think it would be best for you to discuss this separately with my eldest brother later.”

“My thoughts differ from yours, Benefactor.”

“Excuse me?”

“This is a transaction you are fully capable of deciding. Of course, there would need to be many discussions.”

“A transaction worth trading three Peak martial arts for… Then what would our side have to give?”

“A person.”

“A person?”

For an instant, a smile flickered across Lee Seowol’s lips.

It was the second time I had seen her smile, and this time, I knew I hadn’t imagined it.

“Please marry me.”

“Well, I’ll be going.”

Hyuk Mujin, who had been pacing around the pavilion’s front courtyard, turned at the sound of a woman’s voice behind him.

A beauty who made his chest tickle just by looking at her was descending the pavilion steps.

Good heavens. She’s breathtaking.

Though she was dozens of paces away, it almost seemed as if the cold midwinter wind carried the scent of flowers.

Our squad leader sure is lucky.

He had a handsome face, was the youngest Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan—the universally acknowledged foremost family in Shanxi—and possessed excellent martial arts.

When he was with Wolhwa, the words *a celestial beauty and a handsome man* fit them perfectly.

And now the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect had been added to the list.

Hyuk Mujin let out a deep sigh as he watched Lee Seowol's back disappear into the distance.

I loved you, however briefly, Young Lady Lee.

When Hyuk Mujin returned to the pavilion, he found Jin Taekyung sitting there half out of his mind.

"Squad Leader, what's wrong?"

"…"

"Squad Leader. Please come to your senses!"

Only after Hyuk Mujin grabbed him by the shoulders and shook him did his unfocused eyes finally clear.

Hyuk Mujin asked with a worried expression, "Did something happen? Why are you suddenly acting like this?"

Gulp.

Jin Taekyung swallowed hard and barely managed to open his mouth.

"Mujin."

"Yes."

"Do you know how old Lee Seowol is?"

"What do you mean, 'Lee Seowol'? You should call her Sect Leader or Young Lady."

"Unless you want people calling you the late Hyuk Mujin, shut up and answer."

"…"

Hyuk Mujin thought for a moment.

"How old was she again? I think she was about the age when people started getting married."

He suddenly slapped his forehead.

"Oh, I remember."

"H-How old is she?"

"Seventeen."

Jin Taekyung's mouth fell open.

"Fuck, she was still a high schooler?"

Chapter 122

Two things mattered when conveying information: speed and accuracy.

To that end, the Lower District Sect, which dealt in information, had established a dense information network around each of its branches.

Wolhwa had the authority to issue mobilization orders to the more than thirty branches established throughout Shanxi Province.

“How did it go? Is everything taken care of?”

A clean-cut middle-aged man answered her. He was the Jeongyang Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect.

“We separated and moved all the corpses. There were no more survivors from the Mount Heng Sword Sect, but some of the mounted bandits were still breathing.”

“How many?”

“Exactly forty-seven.”

“Quite a lot survived. How many can we save?”

“With the medicine we have on hand, thirty at most.”

“We don’t need to save every last one.”

At Wolhwa’s words, the Jeongyang Branch Leader bowed his head.

“I’ll see to it.”

That decided the surviving mounted bandits’ fates.

Those with severe injuries would rejoin the mountain-high pile of their comrades, while those with minor injuries might have their lives extended a little longer.

Of course, the moment their treatment was finished, they would be sold as slaves to the mines or fighting pits.

“Next. Honju Branch Leader?”

“No problems on our end, either.”

The Honju Branch Leader was a hulking man whose face was covered in sword scars. He scratched his stiff, wirelike beard and continued.

“Truth is, we didn’t even need to step in. They must’ve heard that Pung Yang was dead and the Red Wind Band had been smashed, because they didn’t come anywhere near the area.”

“For now, that’s enough. Pick your fastest, most loose-lipped people and have them spread the rumor. They’ll run away on their own.”

Although Pung Yang and his subordinates had been dealt with, a considerable number of mounted bandits were still prowling around the area like wolves.

They were watching for a chance to sink their teeth into the easy prey that was the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi and the Heaven Shaking Sword beat Pung Yang to death with a single blow. Something like that should scare them out of their wits.”

“It’s not exactly true, but… spice it up as much as you need to. We can’t shed blood over someone else’s fight, can we?”

Whether the rumor was true didn’t matter. All that mattered was spreading the word that the two brothers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had rescued the Mount Heng Sword Sect from Pung Yang and the Red Wind Band.

“Besides, the Jin Family of Taiyuan will make its move within a few days. Unless they’re complete idiots, they’ll return to Gaoyuan if they want to live.”

Word would soon spread far and wide that the great tiger known as the Jin Family of Taiyuan stood behind the Mount Heng Sword Sect. Wouldn’t one roar from the mountain lord[727] be enough to send those bandits running?

“Five days at most. Let’s hold out until then.”

The two Branch Leaders nodded.

“It’s hardly a hardship. These are the Chief Branch Leader’s orders. Of course we’ll obey.”

“I’m fine with it. Maybe it’s because Gaoyuan is right next door, but there’s something fun about riding across all this open land.”

“Glad to hear it.”

Wolhwa let out a short laugh and drew on her long-stemmed tobacco pipe.

“Um, by the way…”

“Yes?”

The Honju Branch Leader, considered the most aggressive and martial-arts-obsessed of her subordinates, had a bright gleam in his eyes.

“I heard from the wounded that bastard Pung Yang took down the Tiger of Mount Heng and the Heaven Shaking Sword all by himself. Is that true?”

“It is. Though I didn’t see it myself.”

“Wow. That’s impressive.”

“It is. Though the fact that he grew so strong so quickly reeks of something fishy.”

The Peak realm was a domain of enlightenment. From that point onward, a martial artist had to go beyond physical training and see through the principles of martial arts in order to advance to a higher realm.

But Pung Yang had been defeated by Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng, only a short while ago. No matter how much enlightenment supported him, he had become far too strong in far too little time.

Wolhwa, who still knew nothing of the Temporary Strength Pill, focused on that point.

“He definitely used some kind of trick… I’ll have to look into it more closely.”

The quick-witted Jeongyang Branch Leader gave a silent bow, while the Honju Branch Leader vigorously scratched the back of his head.

[727] “Mountain lord” is a traditional epithet for a tiger.

“Of course, Pung Yang, that mounted-bandit bastard, is impressive too. But I was talking about someone else.”

“Who? Ah.”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. Isn’t he incredible? According to what our sect has determined, his martial arts are still only First Rate, but he defies our expectations every time.”

Information had to be based on objective facts. As members of the Lower District Sect, they coolly judged how information could be used from a third-party perspective, then applied it to people and situations.

In that regard, Jin Taekyung was a headache. Every prediction they made about him proved wrong.

“But the strange thing is, I’m starting to look forward to it more and more.”

“Look forward to what?”

“Wondering how he’ll defy our expectations next time. That kind of anticipation.”

The Honju Branch Leader had been grinning, but his smile vanished at Wolhwa’s impassive expression.

“My apologies. I was running my mouth…”

“At least you know it. Go outside and handle your work.”

After driving the two Branch Leaders out, Wolhwa put her pipe back between her lips.

A tiny voice slipped from her barely moving lips along with the smoke.

“Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung.”

She suddenly remembered a conversation she had once shared with her Master.

“There are people like that. People who always defy prediction. People who cannot be judged through information.”

“Then what should I do?”

“Do not judge them. Simply watch until you can reach your own conclusion about them.”

“What if I still can’t reach a conclusion after all that?”

“Unpredictable. If such a person exists, wouldn’t they possess the makings of someone who might one day move the world?”

The makings of someone who could move the world…

Wolhwa tapped the ash from her pipe and left the pavilion.

Night had fallen thick and dark. Using the blazing torches as guideposts, she walked until she stopped in front of the pavilion where Jin Taekyung was staying.

“What are you doing out here?”

Hyuk Mujin, who had been squatting miserably in front of the pavilion, brightened when he saw Wolhwa.

“Oh, you’re here?”

“Things are mostly wrapped up, so I stopped by for a moment. Young Master Jin is inside, right?”

In truth, there was no need to ask. Bright light was spilling out through the pavilion.

But Hyuk Mujin shook his head, his expression grim.

“He isn’t inside?”

“No, he is. It’s just…”

Hyuk Mujin let out a deep sigh before continuing.

“His condition isn’t very good. He’s been muttering things that make no sense for a while now. I get goose bumps just looking at him.”

“Things that make no sense?”

“Yes. Do you happen to know what ‘school lunch’ means?”[728]

“School lunch?”

Wolhwa tilted her head. She had read plenty of books, but she had never heard the expression before.

“I don’t think so. It’s new to me.”

“Right? I thought maybe I was just too ignorant to know.”

“And then?”

“You know what our Captain is like. He kept saying ‘school lunch, school lunch,‘ so I asked him what it meant. Then he threw me out.”

Judging by the miserable look on his face as he rubbed his forehead, he hadn’t been shown the door gently.

What happened?

Unable to contain her curiosity, Wolhwa was about to knock when an eerie voice seeped through the gap in the door.

“School lunch, high schooler, clank, clank…”

Goose bumps prickled across Wolhwa’s skin, and she involuntarily stepped back.

“D-Did you hear that?”

“He’s been like that for a while.”

Even as the incomprehensible muttering continued, she backed away in hesitant steps.

“I-I’ll come back another time.”

She realized it once again.

The man named Jin Taekyung was still utterly unpredictable.

[728] “School lunch” is Korean slang for a school-age child. The later “clank, clank” evokes handcuffs or prison bars.

Two days flew by in the blink of an eye. Lee Seowol did not come back after that night, and I didn't bother leaving the pavilion, either.

Even as I spent most of my time learning to control my newly acquired Scorching Yang Qi, her final words kept returning to me.

"Marriage is one of life's great human obligations, so take your time thinking it over."

I had been so flustered at the time that I could only open and close my mouth.

Who would have thought a woman would propose to me first—and a girl who looked so much younger than me, at that?

Although it was a cold political marriage proposal—cold enough that calling it a transaction wasn't an exaggeration—a proposal was still a proposal.

The greater shock, however, was still to come.

Seventeen years old? Is this for real?

A first-year high school student was right in the prime school-lunch-eating years.

She was two years younger than my late-born little sister, Hayeon, and a full ten years younger than me.

That's the Murim for you…

This was a world where getting married in middle school and becoming a parent in high school wouldn't even be strange. If anything, the three brothers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan looked like the oddballs for remaining unmarried at our age.

No, wait a second.

"What are you staring at?"

Jin Mukyung noticed my gaze and asked irritably. He had suffered considerable injuries at Pung Yang's hands, but he had now recovered enough to move around on his own.

Come to think of it…

I had never heard whether Jin Mukyung was married.

I opened my mouth, half expecting the worst.

"Just asking in case."

"What?"

"Are you married?"

Pffft!

Jin Mukyung spat tea into my face and hurriedly shouted.

"W-What kind of nonsense is that?"

"If you're not, then you're not. Why are you so flustered?"

After receiving that unexpected facial wash, I wiped my face with my sleeve and continued asking questions.

"Why haven't you married?"

Jin Mukyung seemed flustered for a moment, then answered readily.

"I'm too busy training in martial arts. Women are a luxury to me."

"You make it sound downright frugal."

"Don't lump me in with a lecherous idler like you. That's an insult to me."

"…"

Lecherous, my ass. I had spent all twenty-seven years of my life single.

If dating was a luxury, then I was the very definition of a miser. The only slight difference was that while Jaringobi[729] ate rice while staring at a strip of dried fish, I had a USB drive.

"What's with that expression? You look incredibly sad."

"Call it regret over the life I've lived."

"At last, you're becoming human."

He seemed to have a different interpretation of my past life, but fine. He could interpret it however he wanted.

"But why did you suddenly ask about marriage? It's something you already know perfectly well."

"Oh, because the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect asked me to marry her."

Pffft!

"…For fuck's sake. Stop spitting."

As I wiped away the second mouthful of tea, Jin Mukyung regained his composure.

"The Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

"Yeah. She said it two days ago."

"Why on earth would she marry someone like you… Ah, of course. It must be a political marriage."

"…"

He wasn't wrong, but it was still pretty damn irritating. At this point, wasn't I prime husband material both in the Murim and in the real world?

"So, are you thinking of doing it?"

"Of course not. How could I marry a girl so much younger than me?"

"You're barely twenty, and you say things like that."

My body is twenty, but my mind is twenty-seven, you bastard.

Besides, I had decided on my answer to Lee Seowol's proposal long ago.

You can't set up two households when there's someone you love. There was only one person in my heart right now.

What could Song-i be doing right now?

[729] Jaringobi is a figure in a Korean story about miserliness who stares at dried fish while eating rice instead of eating the fish.

Just imagining it made me happy. I tilted my teacup with a blissful smile, and Jin Mukyung stared at me with a bizarre expression.

“What a disgusting look.”

“Anyway, I’m turning down the marriage for various reasons.”

“You made the right decision. At the very least, a political marriage has to offer us something in return. If you marry someone you have no feelings for and gain nothing from it, there’s no reason to enter into a political marriage.”

I had thought he was a fool who knew nothing but martial arts, but every now and then, he became a surprisingly sharp realist.

“And no matter what they offer, it’s out of the question as long as our eldest brother is around. He isn’t the sort of man who would bind you through a political marriage.”

“They did make a pretty substantial offer, though.”

“Hm. What did they say they would give you?”

Jin Mukyung tilted his teacup with an uninterested expression.

“The Blood Wolf Sword Technique, the Blood Wolf Footwork, and the Shura Annihilating Fist.”

Pffft!

“…Ah, fuck.”

This time, I didn’t even have time to wipe my face. Jin Mukyung grabbed me by the collar and shook me hard.

“Marry her right now!”

Chapter 123

A middle-aged man lay in bed, his entire body wrapped in bandages.

His brow was deeply furrowed, as if something was bothering him, and his body kept fidgeting without a moment's rest.

"Ugh."

The moment he groaned, a sharp rebuke followed.

"Please don't move so much."

"That's not it…"

"Uncle Cheol, didn't you hear what the physician said?"

Here we go again. Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng, stared blankly at the ceiling. Lee Seowol pulled a thick cotton blanket up to his chest and continued.

"You need to recover as quickly as possible. I know you're restless, but please stay in bed. At least get some more sleep."

"I've already slept enough."

"You only slept for one shichen[730]."

"Only? One shichen[731] is plenty."

"You'll only make your injuries worse."

"I've lived like this for more than thirty years. I'll be fine."

"That's because you've never been this badly injured before."

"…Ugh."

Cheol Mubaek fell silent at Seowol's pointed remark.

She was right. He had never suffered injuries this severe since learning the Shura Annihilating Fist. Broken limbs and serious internal injuries. According to the physician, his injuries were severe enough to require at least four months of recuperation.

"I wasn't this badly hurt even when I met your father."

Seowol reacted to his complaint.

"My father?"

"Yes. That friend of mine, Cheonbaek."

"What happened between the two of you?"

"Did I never tell you?"

"I only knew that you hit it off and became friends."

"We did. But first, we fought with our lives on the line."

"You fought?"

Cheol Mubaek smiled faintly.

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[730] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[731] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"What else would two martial artists do when they met? We were both young and fiercely competitive, so what happened next was obvious."

Cheol Mubaek looked out the window. More than thirty years ago, somewhere along those towering mountain ridges, the two men had met for the first time—and fought.

"He said he'd spent three months combing the mountain range to find me. He looked like a beggar, but his aura was anything but ordinary."

Masters recognized masters. Cheol Mubaek had secluded himself in a remote mountain valley where no one ever ventured, training alone. Lee Cheonbaek had perfected his own martial arts through countless battles.

It was the first meeting of two Peak masters.

"He told me to become his subordinate. He said he was going to establish a sect at the foot of the mountains and wanted me to help lay its foundation."

"That sounds like Father. So what happened?"

"What else was there to say? We fought. Viciously."

Seowol let out a quiet laugh.

"I see."

"Aren't you curious how it ended?"

"Do I need to hear it? The fact that you've remained unaffiliated all this time tells me everything, Uncle Cheol. Isn't this one of those embarrassing stories about two men becoming friends after being impressed by each other's martial arts?"

"Ha-ha-ha! Exactly! The fight was decided after precisely five hundred exchanges… Ugh."

Cheol Mubaek had been laughing heartily when a sudden stab of pain made him flinch. Seowol sighed.

"I think having me here is making your condition worse… Perhaps I should leave."

"You little rascal. Don't you feel sorry for your uncle, growing old all alone?"

"If you're interested, just tell me anytime. I'll even play matchmaker for you."

"Forget it. What would I do at my age?"

Although he had said the words himself, they left a bitter taste in his mouth. Cheol Mubaek muttered inwardly.

Yes. Somehow, I've grown this old.

He did not even know exactly how many years had passed since the day he lost his family.

His deep internal energy and rigorously trained body merely made him look younger than his true age. His spirit had been growing old for a long time.

My one and only friend is gone, and the martial arts I spent my entire life honing were utterly crushed. Heh.

Only now could he finally admit it.

The Tiger of Mount Heng had grown old.

But Cheol Mubaek still had something left to protect.

“Seowol.”

Seowol answered him warmly.

“Yes, Uncle?”

“I want you to be happy.”

“I know.”

“It isn’t too late. Marry someone you love. With the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s help, you could build a safe, happy home anywhere in Shanxi.”

“What I want isn’t a home. It’s the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

Sorrow flickered in Cheol Mubaek’s eyes. He had watched Seowol grow from infancy. Rebuilding and restoring a fallen sect was far too heavy a burden for a girl not yet twenty.

“You may regret the choice you’re making now.”

“But no matter what choice I make, you’ll believe in me, won’t you?”

“If I didn’t, I wouldn’t have given you the martial arts manual for the Shura Annihilating Fist.”

Seowol grasped Cheol Mubaek’s wrinkled hand.

She, too, was the daughter of a martial household. She understood what a momentous decision the old martial artist before her had made.

“Thank you, Uncle.”

At the moisture in her voice, Cheol Mubaek waved a hand.

“I’m old. I was already having trouble taking on a Disciple at my age, so this was simply a good opportunity.”

The Shura Annihilating Fist followed the principles of a single successor and transmission only to the worthy. Its purpose was to preserve the martial lineage by finding a successor of upright conduct and good character.

Yet Cheol Mubaek, its ninth-generation successor, had broken those principles and handed the martial arts manual to Seowol. Though he had not taught her directly, he had still broken a tradition passed down through generations of his school.

But Cheol Mubaek had his own reasons.

The Heaven Shaking Sword and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi should be able to protect Seowol.

If Seowol had decided on a political marriage, those two were her best options.

Their martial talent went without saying, and they possessed the chivalrous spirit to risk their lives fighting injustice.

Still, I’ll have to watch and see what they’re really like…

If all went well, this path could fulfill both the purpose of the political marriage and the traditions of a single successor and transmission only to the worthy.

“So, about that…”

Cheol Mubaek continued in a suggestive tone.

“Which one did you choose?”

Seowol tilted her head, feigning ignorance.

“My, whatever do you mean?”

“Don’t play dumb. Is it the Heaven Shaking Sword? Or the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“I’m not sure.”

“They’re much the same, but… Wouldn’t the Heaven Shaking Sword be better?”

“You don’t like the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“It’s not that I dislike him…”

Cheol Mubaek frowned. Even he, who spent most of the year deep in the mountains, had heard the rumors about the notorious good-for-nothing of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“Even if he has turned over a new leaf, old habits die hard. I worry that he may break your heart someday.”

“What about the Heaven Shaking Sword?”

Cheol Mubaek’s crumpled expression smoothed out.

“They say no younger brother measures up to his elder. I spoke with him briefly yesterday, and he seemed like a fine man. His martial talent is outstanding.”

“I heard he knows nothing but martial arts.”

“Hey! That’s far better than chasing women. His speech and conduct are dignified, and he carries himself with proper gravity. That’s how a man ought to be. Yes, indeed.”

Cheol Mubaek smiled contentedly.

Jin Mukyung grabbed me by the collar and shook me violently, his eyes half rolled back in his head.

“Marry her right now!”

“Cough! Cough!”

Tea had already gone up my nose and left me choking. With Mukyung shaking me nonstop by the collar on top of that, I couldn’t think straight.

“Let go! Are you going to let go or not?”

“The Shura Annihilating Fist! The Blood Wolf Sword Technique! The Blood Wolf Footwork!”

“I get it, so let go first!”

“You stupid bastard! Do you even know what kind of martial art the Shura Annihilating Fist is?”

“Let go and then we’ll talk!”

“A single successor! Transmission only to the worthy!”

“Enough, you crazy bastard!”

A short while later, by the time I finally pried Mukyung’s hand away, the inside of the pavilion looked as though a storm had passed through it.

“Huff… huff…”

I caught my breath and looked around.

The table had collapsed, the chairs had been smashed to pieces, and shards of broken teaware rolled across the floor.

Mukyung calmly straightened his clothes and spoke.

“Hmm. I’ve calmed down.”

“…”

This guy was even crazier than I’d thought.

I scrubbed my face with the less-soaked sleeve.

“Is the Shura Annihilating Fist the greatest martial art under heaven or something? Why are you so obsessed with it?”

“It ranks among the ten greatest fist techniques under heaven. No—it did.”

“It did?”

“Two hundred years ago. Even in the library of Heaven’s Gate Temple, which holds thousands, even tens of thousands of books, that martial art survives only in written records. And to think that the Great Hero Tiger of Mount Heng was the current successor to the Shura Annihilating Fist!”

His cheeks flushed red from excitement at the mere thought.

I blew the tea out of my nose and asked, “So?”

“What? What do you mean, ‘so’?”

Mukyung stared at me in disbelief.

“This is the Shura Annihilating Fist we’re talking about! A Peak martial art whose lineage was believed to have died out long ago!”

“And it was one of the ten greatest fist techniques under heaven two hundred years ago?”

“Exactly!”

“Wait a second.”

I picked up a thick wooden stick lying on the floor. Until five minutes ago, it had been known as a table leg.

“Know what this is?”

“A club?”

"You know your stuff."

"What does that have to do with anything?"

"About two thousand years ago, wouldn't this have been one of the ten greatest weapons under heaven or something?"

He wasn't stupid enough to miss my point.

Mukyung glared at me.

"How dare you compare the Shura Annihilating Fist to something like that."

"Then what's the difference?"

"That's…"

"Sure, it's worth far more than a wooden club. But does it still hold the same value now?"

In the past, mankind had fought with stones and clubs. But when bronze and iron appeared, the march of time left them behind.

The Shura Annihilating Fist was no different.

"Of course, it's still an outstanding Peak martial art that everyone would want."

Cheol Mubaek himself had proven that. With the Shura Annihilating Fist, he had become a renowned Peak master in Shanxi Province.

"But it's not still one of the ten greatest fist techniques under heaven, is it?"

Just as stone and wooden clubs had given way to steel, martial arts had also advanced.

I had no idea what the ten greatest fist techniques under heaven were now, but Mukyung's expression proved my point.

"To put it bluntly, if the Shura Annihilating Fist were really that powerful, Cheol Mubaek wouldn't have lost to Pung Yang. And here's the most important part…"

I tossed the table leg into a corner and drove the final nail home.

"I have no intention of getting married."

"…!"

"What can you do when the person involved refuses? Right?"

"Well… That's true."

Mukyung heaved one sigh after another. I'd been ready to fight him if he kept insisting, but he accepted it surprisingly easily.

Still, the wistful look in his eyes suggested that he couldn't stop thinking about the Shura Annihilating Fist manual.

This guy is a martial arts nut too.

Then again, he had gone to Heaven's Gate Temple because he wanted to learn more martial arts.

Now he had discovered a centuries-old martial art that survived only in the records of that very temple. No wonder he was beside himself.

"Hoo…"

Mukyung let out a sigh deep enough to make the earth cave in and muttered,

“What a shame. What a shame.”

“It’s not that big a deal. If fate brings it around, we can get it another time.”

“You idiot. Do you think Peak martial arts just drop out of the sky?”

“Really? Mine did.”

“Even at Heaven’s Gate Temple, where all the martial arts under heaven are gathered, Peak martial arts are strictly controlled… What did you say?”

“I said mine fell out of the sky.”

I pulled an old book from inside my robes. The four characters on its cover had faded under the ravages of time, but they remained clear enough to read.

Flame Divine Palm.

A tiger leaves its hide when it dies, and Jopil left behind a Supreme Peak martial art.

“Fl-Fl-Flame…”

Today was probably the most astonishing day of Jin Mukyung’s entire life.

I grinned as his eyes bulged and darted between me and the martial arts manual.

“From now on, call me hyung[732].”

[732] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Chapter 124

I was only human, so I couldn't help wavering when Lee Seowol presented me with three martial arts manuals two nights ago.

They were Supreme Peak martial arts, no less. Now that I had mastered the Jin Family's Spear Technique and Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique, I had already been feeling the need to learn something new. Then someone dangled such a tempting offer right in front of me.

I can't go on like this.

My fight with Pung Yang had been brutal. If not for the Unnamed Sword I'd obtained from Jopil, even two lives wouldn't have been enough to survive.

It was time to learn more martial arts and reach a new realm.

Peak master.

The Blood Wolf Sword Technique, Blood Wolf Footwork, and Shura Annihilating Fist were all proven Peak martial arts—sturdy hammers capable of breaking through the supposedly insurmountable wall of the Peak realm. But…

If those are hammers, then this is an excavator.

I gazed proudly at the old book in my hand.

This single martial arts manual was why I could reject Lee Seowol's proposal without much regret.

"Fl, fl, fl, fl…"

After buffering for quite some time, Jin Mukyung finally managed to spit out a single word.

"Flame Divine Palm!"

"Oh, you know it? Correct."

Jin Mukyung even knew the ten greatest fist techniques in the world from two hundred years ago, so perhaps it was only natural that he knew about the Flame Divine Palm. This martial art was even more incredible than those.

Check item.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Flame Divine Palm
Type: Martial arts manual
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Owner of Scorching Yang Qi
Description: One of the Fire Gate Clan's secret techniques. A martial art based on powerful fire qi.
Effect: Acquisition of Flame Divine Palm.

Jin Mukyung asked in disbelief.

"How did you get this…?"

"Some generous soul gave it to me before he left."

"He gave it to you?"

"Yeah."

He gave it to me and then flew away to heaven.

The Unnamed Sword, made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron capable of destroying even Body-Protecting Qi. The Blazing Flame Divine Pill, which could grant thirty years of Scorching Yang Qi.

And finally, the Flame Divine Palm, a Supreme Peak martial art.

Thinking of Jopil, who had given me so much before leaving this world, I gazed at the blue sky beyond the window.

Hope you're doing well.

That was when Jin Mukyung abruptly cut in.

"Enough nonsense. Tell me the truth. How did a secret technique of the Fire Gate Clan end up in your hands?"

"I told you. Someone gave it to me before he left."

"You seem to be misunderstanding something…"

Jin Mukyung continued with a serious expression.

"This isn't a situation you can gloss over with a joke."

"Why not?"

"Because you could be branded a thief who stole another sect's martial art. If this goes badly, our family could face condemnation from the entire Murim."

That was a problem I hadn't considered.

A sect's martial arts were its foundation and its history. The Flame Divine Palm was not only a Supreme Peak martial art but also a secret technique of the Fire Gate Clan. That went without saying.

"Ah, damn it."

“I’ll ask you one more time. Where and how did you acquire the Flame Divine Palm manual?”

I let out a deep sigh before answering.

“From Jopil.”

“Jopil? The One Question, One Kill Jopil I know?”

“That’s right. I defeated him and took it as spoils.”

“Do you know how that bastard came to possess the Flame Divine Palm manual?”

“Not really…”

After thinking carefully, I remembered what Jopil had said at the time.

“He claimed he was the nineteenth-generation successor to the Flame Divine Palm.”

“How could someone like Jopil… Are you sure you didn’t mishear him?”

“No, I’m sure. He didn’t look like he was lying, either.”

At the time, Jopil had been drawing on his innate qi and was already dying fast. Most words spoken by someone on the brink of death were close to the truth.

Of course, I have to consider the possibility that Jopil was lying.

Jin Mukyung, who had been lost in thought, spoke with a look of bafflement.

“If he was the successor to the Flame Divine Palm, how did he lose to someone like you?”

“…”

Well, that pissed me off, but he had a point.

It was suspicious enough that Jopil had been living as a wandering martial artist despite having learned a Supreme Peak martial art.

Come to think of it, he couldn’t even use Sword Energy properly.

These days, every martial artist I met came with Sword Energy as standard and Body-Protecting Qi as an optional extra. One Question, One Kill Jopil had been among the weakest Peak masters I had fought so far.

“Is the Flame Divine Palm weaker than I thought?”

“What? The Flame Divine Palm is weak?”

Jin Mukyung looked at me as if I were the craziest person he had ever seen.

“You lunatic. You’re probably the only person under heaven who would call the Fire King’s signature martial art weak.”

“Who’s the Fire King?”

“I’m not in the mood for jokes.”

“Neither am I.”

“Stop it. It isn’t funny.”

“Okay. So who’s the Fire King?”

This silence lasted a little longer. Jin Mukyung opened and closed his mouth like a goldfish before letting out a deep sigh.

“Count your fingers and toes. How many are there altogether?”

“Twenty.”

“Right. Even if you turned the whole world upside down and shook it out, the Fire King would still rank among its twenty greatest masters.”

“…Whoa.”

“One God, Three Saints, Ten Kings. You’ve never heard of them? You seriously don’t know?”

He looked ready to twist my neck if I said I had never heard of any of them.

Faced with Jin Mukyung’s wide-eyed stare, I cautiously opened my mouth.

“I’ve heard of the Three Saints, at least…”

“That’s something.”

I meant Samsung,[733] not the Three Saints, but whatever.

That wasn’t important right now.

“Then if the Fire King finds out I have the Flame Divine Palm…”

“Something you’d rather not imagine will probably happen.”

Damn it. A Supreme Peak master ranked among the twenty greatest experts in the entire world. If the Fire King learned about this and came looking for me, the entire Jin Family of Taiyuan could attack him together and still lose.

After everything it took to get this martial art…

My gut twisted at the thought of handing it over without even learning it.

At that moment, Jin Mukyung, who had been gazing at the Flame Divine Palm manual just as regretfully as I was, added,

“If the Fire King is still alive, that is.”

“What?”

“The Fire King last appeared forty years ago.”

“Forty years ago?”

“He was already an old man when he first appeared in the Murim. If not for the Great Faction War, he might have spent his entire life as a secluded eccentric.”

Jin Mukyung continued.

“The Demonic Cult’s morale soared after it defeated the Namgung Family and occupied Anhui Province. Its members looted, murdered, and committed arson on a massive scale. Apparently, setting fire to Mount Jiuhua was what finally provoked the Fire King.”

“And then?”

---

[733] Samsung is a Korean company. Its name is pronounced *Samseong*, like the Korean title rendered here as “Three Saints.”

“A thousand people died over four days and nights, and the old man who had been living in seclusion deep within Mount Jiuhua gained the name Fire King.”

“…A thousand people?”

“Yes. The Demonic Cult suffered such heavy losses at Mount Jiuhua that it could not hold out for long and had to withdraw from Anhui Province.”

A thousand people, huh…

After careful consideration, I spoke.

“Let’s give it back.”

I wanted to live a long life. I didn’t want an event involving some insane old man who had single-handedly killed a thousand people added to my life.

“We should leave right away. Anhui Province? Do people still say he lives there?”

“No one knows. Perhaps that still hadn’t been enough to quell the Fire King’s anger. He spent an entire year crushing every Demonic Cult member he could find before disappearing into seclusion again.”

“The Fire Gate Clan! We can find him if we go to the Fire Gate Clan.”

“The Fire Gate Clan has only one successor at a time. It’s similar to Great Hero Cheol’s situation.”

“…”

So even if I wanted to return it, there was no one to give it to.

Jopil had probably been the person closest to the Fire King, but he was already dead. I had no way to find the man.

The best-case scenario is that the Fire King is already dead…

He had already been an old man forty years ago, so it was entirely possible.

On the other hand, as a Supreme Peak master, he might have lived an extraordinarily long life.

“Hmm.”

Was this a priceless treasure or a useless burden? As I stared at the Flame Divine Palm with a conflicted expression, Jin Mukyung said,

“If the Fire King is dead… then you’re the master of the Fire Gate Clan now.”

Jin Mukyung recovered quickly. He had suffered considerable internal injuries from Pung Yang, so a full recovery would still take some time, but he had enough strength to return to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“We’re finally going home.”

Hyuk Mujin muttered with a deeply moved expression.

“They say leaving home means hardship. From now on, I will never, ever leave the family grounds again!”

"…Anyone listening would think you suffered the most, you punk."

"What are you talking about? I have my own hardships, you know."

"Try saying that to the person behind you."

Jin Mukyung, who still hadn't been able to remove his bandages, came flying over and smacked Hyuk Mujin on the back of the head.

Whack!

"Urk!"

"Enough nonsense. Drive the carriage."

"There's a coachman. Why do I have to…?"

Just as Hyuk Mujin said, we had a separate coachman—a member of the Lower District Sect whom Wolhwa had assigned to us.

Wolhwa had come out ahead of time to see us off.

"Goodbye. It's a shame to part now that the time has come, isn't it?"

"Then would you like to come with us now?"

I spoke jokingly to her as she winked at me. I was still wary of her, but after our journey together, we had become close enough to exchange jokes.

"Oh my, I'd love to, but… I'm planning to take this opportunity to tour all of northern Shanxi."

Northern Shanxi, which the Mount Heng Sword Sect had kept under tight control until now, had become an open market. Naturally, Wolhwa—the Lower District Sect's Chief Branch Leader for Shanxi Province—would be busy.

"Things must have gone well with the Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

"Secret. I may be the Chief Branch Leader, but I can't go around telling outsiders our sect's confidential information."

Her words said one thing, but her bright, carefree smile was answer enough.

She was the sort of woman who could have nine tails[734] and no one would find it strange, so she had probably obtained a more than satisfactory result.

"I suppose we'll meet at the Jin Family of Taiyuan next time."

"Oh, really?"

"We were allies once. Wouldn't it be better for both of us if we continued to maintain a close relationship?"

Wolhwa smiled coyly and lifted the hem of her skirt slightly.

"Make sure you come see me again then. Well, I'll be off."

As soon as she climbed into the waiting carriage, the coachman cracked his whip. Two pairs of eyes gazed blankly after the carriage as it rapidly receded into the distance.

"Tsk. She could've stayed a little longer."

[734] A *gumiho* is a nine-tailed fox in Korean folklore, often depicted as a cunning shapeshifter.

“Hmm. Mmm…”

Hyuk Mujin was one thing, but what was Jin Mukyung’s deal?

As I watched the wistful look in his eyes, a thought suddenly occurred to me.

Could that bastard possibly…?

Was he interested in Wolhwa?

Good heavens. I couldn’t believe it. The man who knew nothing but martial arts was showing an interest in a woman.

I couldn’t keep this earth-shattering news to myself. I moved close to Hyuk Mujin and whispered in a voice as small as an ant.

“Hey, Mujin.”

“Ah! You startled me. What is it?”

“Shh. Listen, but don’t be surprised. Don’t show even the slightest reaction. This is a secret we have to take to our graves.”

Hyuk Mujin answered in a stiff voice.

“Gasp. Yes. Go ahead.”

“I think that guy… is interested in Young Lady Wolhwa.”

“…”

“Don’t tell anyone. This is a secret only I know, and I’m telling you alone.”

Despite my serious whisper, Hyuk Mujin replied with a sour expression.

“Oh, yes. Thank you. I’m so grateful I don’t know what to do with myself.”

Why, this little shit…

I was wondering how to correct that rude tone when—

“Benefactor.”

I slowly turned around.

Lee Seowol stood there in a snow-white palace robe.

Chapter 125

“Benefactor.”

Lee Seowol looked especially beautiful today. She wore a snow-white formal robe, and her hair gleamed where it had been swept up with a jade hairpin.

She still looked haggard from everything she had been through, but she was so dazzlingly beautiful that even her exhaustion seemed charming.

No. What am I thinking?

Beautiful? Charming? At seventeen, she should still be wearing a school uniform and worrying about her grades, not marriage.

She was two years younger than Hayeon, putting ten years between us. With an age gap like that, she might as well have been my niece.

Still, she certainly seems mature for her age… No. Get a grip.

Avoiding Lee Seowol’s deep gaze, I clasped my hands in a formal salute.

“Greetings.”

“I greet the Sect Leader.”

Lee Seowol was no ordinary girl. She was the Sect Leader responsible for an entire sect. Just as she was about to return Jin Mukyung’s and my polite greetings—

“Imagine the Sect Leader of the great Mount Heng Sword Sect coming out to greet us in person! I, Hyuk Mujin, am truly honored!”

Of course. It wouldn’t be complete without you.

Hyuk Mujin kept his eyes fixed on her as he bowed over and over. All I could do was sigh.

“I apologize. He’s not all there.”

“…Captain.”

“You saw that, right? We’re not even close, but he’s pretending we are. You’ll be better off ignoring him.”

A faint dimple appeared at the corner of Lee Seowol’s mouth.

“Not at all. He’s also a Benefactor who fought for our sect.”

“It’s fine. He didn’t lift a finger, so you don’t have to count him as a Benefactor.”

“…Oh. I see.”

At my helpful fact-check, her smile turned awkward. Just then, a rough voice came from behind her.

“He’s a Benefactor to me.”

The speaker was a middle-aged man with half-gray hair. Seated in a rattling wooden cart, he greeted us with a nod.

“Please excuse me for being unable to stand. Well, age has caught up with me. My body isn’t what it used to be.”

No one here could match the man before us in either age or fame.

At the appearance of Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng, Hyuk Mujin quickly bent at the waist.

“I greet Great Hero Cheol Mubaek—”

“Is this your first time seeing my face? Spare me the tiresome formalities.”

“But you’re a renowned great senior of the Murim…”

“Senior, my foot. If you fuss over every little distinction like that, life in the Murim gets exhausting.”

“…”

Look at how laid-back this old man was.

Even Hyuk Mujin, who was as shameless as they came, quietly shrank back. That left Jin Mukyung.

“You’ve arrived.”

Nothing special. He simply clasped his hands in a brief salute. Yet Cheol Mubaek’s face lit up the instant he saw him.

“Well, if it isn’t our Heaven Shaking Sword. So, you’re leaving now?”

“It seems so.”

“Why not stay a little longer? We could have an in-depth discussion about martial arts later. Hmm?”

“I’m sorry, but I’m pressed for time.”

“Oh, what a shame. It can’t be helped, then. Will you come visit this old man sometime?”

“If a great senior of the martial world is willing to teach me, then I should be the one asking for the opportunity.”

“Ha-ha-ha! Senior, huh? I like the sound of that.”

What exactly was I looking at?

They had only spent three or four days together, but they looked like a close grandfather and grandson.

And what was that? Hadn’t he just said fussing over seniority made life exhausting? Look at him changing his tune.

I shot Hyuk Mujin a glance.

What’s with those two?

No idea. He called me a Benefactor before, but is it really all right to treat people this differently?

But if you’re being honest, you didn’t actually do anything.

…

He clamped his mouth shut with an irritated expression. My meaning seemed to have gotten through.

“All right. Make sure you come next time.”

Cheol Mubaek gazed at Jin Mukyung with a pleased, grandfatherly smile before turning toward me.

“What about you? Don’t you have anything to say?”

Was it my imagination, or had I just felt a predator’s gaze?

I decided to follow the better of the two examples I had just witnessed.

“You’ve arrived.”

“Of course I have. Did I go somewhere?”

“…”

That wasn’t it.

But smiling in hard times was the mark of a First Rate man. I put on a smile without panicking.

“Are you feeling all right?”

This time, Cheol Mubaek shook his splinted limbs.

“Do I look all right?”

“…No.”

“If I were all right, I would’ve walked here. These days, those mounted-bandit bastards work people without even a retirement age. How is an old man like me supposed to keep up?”

“…”

The old man had quite a memory. He still seemed to be holding on to what I had said by mistake when we first met.

Lee Seowol, who knew nothing about the situation, shouted in embarrassment.

“Uncle!”

“Good grief, you’ll burst this old man’s eardrums.”

After grumbling, he suddenly bowed his head politely.

“Thank you, all of you.”

He wasn’t thanking us out of obligation. Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng—an old master who had walked his own path for many years—was speaking from the bottom of his heart.

“Not because you prolonged what little remains of this old man’s life. Seowol—thank you for protecting that child. Thanks to all of you, the Mount Heng Sword Sect survived.”

He gazed calmly at me, Jin Mukyung, and Hyuk Mujin in turn.

“I’ve learned something after living for more than a jiazi.[735] Gratitude and grudges must be repaid, no matter what it takes. I swear here and now that I will never forget what happened, not until the day I die. If you wish it, I’ll repay you even if it costs me my life.”

[735] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

Lee Seowol immediately continued where he left off.

“The Mount Heng Sword Sect will also remember our Benefactors. And for the wrongs committed by my late father… I would like to offer our apology here and now.”

“We apologize!”

“Please forgive us!”

The thunderous cries burst from the mouths of the Mount Heng martial artists.

Every one of them bore injuries, both great and small. Kneeling in the snow that had yet to melt, they waited for our answer.

A light tap.

You answer.

At Jin Mukyung’s Sound Transmission, I licked my parched lips.

Forgiveness.

We had won the war, but wounds remained.

Martial artists had fought and died without end on the orders of their superiors. Even women and children who had never learned martial arts had been sacrificed. It was all the work of Lee Cheonbaek, blinded by his desire to avenge his son.

The wounds left by the war with the Mount Heng Sword Sect ran deep. They would take a long time to heal.

And scars will remain.

Some scars could never be erased.

The young siblings who had lost their home and parents in an instant would carry scars like that. So would I, judging by how the face of that man who had dreamed the absurd dream of becoming the greatest of all time still haunted me.

But I couldn’t deny that the wounds were beginning to close.

Because everyone who caused them is dead.

The Head Elder and Lee Cheonbaek, each of whom had dreamed of revenge, had already met their ends.

Wasn’t that why we had raced here day and night to save the Mount Heng Sword Sect?

With a sincere apology and forgiveness… wounds could heal, even if the scars remained.

Just as they were now.

“I won’t accept your apology.”

The words came out only after considerable thought. Without waiting for anyone else to react, I continued.

“I’m not someone with the right to receive your apology or forgive you.”

No one here had that right. The people they needed to apologize to were back at the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Lee Seowol and Cheol Mubaek seemed to understand. Both nodded.

“I’ll see you on New Year’s Day.”

“Taiyuan, is it? It will be my first journey away from home in thirty years.”

The Mount Heng Sword Sect would hardly be a welcome guest. Especially now, diminished to such a pitiful state, they might have to endure all manner of humiliation and disgrace.

But that was something they would have to bear themselves. There was nothing I could do, nor any reason for me to interfere.

Well done.

With Jin Mukyung’s brief Sound Transmission in my ear, I offered one last farewell.

“Then we’ll be going.”

I had just turned toward the carriage when Lee Seowol called out.

“Benefactor.”

“Yes?”

“Did you know there are fewer than fifteen days left until New Year’s Day?”

Her voice babbled on like a little stream.

“I’m looking forward to hearing the answer I didn’t get last time.”

I could only open and close my mouth in confusion as Jin Mukyung grabbed me and dragged me away.

With Cheol Mubaek’s distinctly displeased cough sounding behind us, the carriage set off at full speed.

The journey back to the Jin Family of Taiyuan was quick and smooth. The coachman’s skill played a part, but with the impatience gone from my heart, everything seemed that way.

“Phew.”

Jin Mukyung had just finished circulating his qi when he suddenly muttered, “Now that I think about it, I didn’t even get to see a Peak martial art.”

He had joined us after Jin Wikyung lured him in with the promise that he could see Peak martial arts at Mount Heng. I answered him calmly.

“It’s fine. Thanks to Pung Yang, you got to see Mount Beimang.[736]”

“You call that consolation?”

“No. I was making fun of you.”

[736] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds and death.

Bones cracked in Jin Mukyung's hand.

"You've grown a lot."

"Want to spar once your injuries are fully healed?"

"I could do it right now… Urgh."

Jin Mukyung tried to spring to his feet, then immediately frowned.

No matter how quickly he recovered, it had only been four days. That was nowhere near enough time for his injuries to heal completely.

He collapsed back into his seat and glared at me.

"Consider yourself lucky."

"I don't know about lucky, but my lifeline sure is damn thick."

Considering how I kept surviving every brush with death, I must have been born with an unusually sturdy lifeline. Either that, or I had been blessed with heaven's fortune.

"Anyway, you did well."

"Huh?"

"Eeeh?"

Hyuk Mujin and I both widened our eyes at the unexpected praise sticker. Jin Mukyung looked at us as if he couldn't understand what was wrong.

"Why are you looking at me like that? You look as if you've heard something you weren't supposed to."

"You're practically a ghost."

"Wait, could Pung Yang have already killed you? Are you sitting here as a vengeful spirit?"

It was a fairly plausible theory, but around Jin Mukyung, you had to watch your mouth at all times.

As I watched Hyuk Mujin get beaten until dust flew, I felt around inside my robes.

Inventory open. Summon.

The next moment, my fingertips touched something round and hard.

It was the only thing Pung Yang had left behind.

No—the only thing I had taken from him.

Check Item.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Temporary Strength Pill
Type: Elixir
Grade: ???
Restriction: Peak martial artist or higher
Description: A pill manufactured by an unknown person. It greatly raises the user's latent power for about one shichen,[737] but a price must be paid in return. Do not take it except in the worst-case scenario.
Effect: Combat-related stats +100
Internal energy: +15 years
Body-Protecting Qi: Available

Even accounting for the short time limit, its effects were monstrous. I could understand why Pung Yang had been so confident.

I had no idea how severe the aftereffects were, but if my life were in danger, I'd swallow twenty of them, not two. Obviously.

But something else bothered me.

A pill manufactured by an unknown person.

The Item's Grade was marked with question marks, its exact aftereffects weren't listed, and even its maker was shrouded in mystery.

What kind of bastard had created something this bizarre?

This thing reeks of something shady.

I was rolling the Temporary Strength Pill around in my palm, lost in thought, when a distant cry drifted toward us.

"Mukyuuung! Taekyuuung!"

Jin Mukyung froze in the middle of enthusiastically hammering Hyuk Mujin's forehead.

"Was that a hallucination?"

Yeah, no.

[737] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours.

Chapter 126

Four days ago, after completing every mission and returning to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Wipeng deeply regretted how efficiently he had handled things.

I should've come back a day later.

But it was already too late. Jin Wikyung had received a messenger eagle from the Lower District Sect and was flying into a rage, his eyes practically rolling back in his head.

"Those goddamn mounted bandits dare!"

"What is it this time?"

"Pung Yang! The Red Wind Band! The Mount Heng Sword Sect! My brothers are in danger! Great danger! We leave at once!"

"…I'll assemble the guards."

Now that every obstacle had been swept aside, Jin Wikyung's authority was absolute. Before even half a shichen[738] had passed, the two left the family grounds with fifty elite guards and raced onward without rest.

Two days later, they stopped at a Lower District Sect branch to change horses and received new information.

"What? Pung Yang is dead, and the Red Wind Band has been annihilated?"

"Yes! According to our sect's intelligence, most of the enemy force—some three hundred men—was wiped out, and Young Master Jin Taekyung defeated Pung Yang himself."

"Oh. Ohhh! Taekyung!"

Jin Wikyung's laughter, as if he had gained the whole world, vanished without a trace at the next words.

"Tell me again. What happened to Mukyung?"

"W-well… he suffered a considerable injury during his life-and-death duel with Pung Yang. But his life isn't in danger, and he's recovering quickly, so there should be no need to worry."

It was already over. Jin Wikyung had probably heard nothing except *considerable injury*.

When his younger brothers were children, if even a thorn pierced one of their fingers, he would raise such a commotion that you would have thought the finger had been severed.

And it wasn't a minor injury. It was a considerable one. This is going to be a disaster.

Experience told Wipeng what would happen next.

Sure enough, he was exactly right.

"Mukyung is hovering between life and death?!"

[738] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

The Lower District Sect member blinked at Jin Wikyung's roar.

"Y-yes?"

"Pung Yang! You dare kill my little brother!"

First Jin Wikyung turned a considerable injury into hovering between life and death, and now he'd pronounced Mukyung dead outright. The Lower District Sect member finally came to his senses and hurriedly opened his mouth.

"Lesser Family Head, I think there's been a terrible misunderstanding…"

"I'll tear your limbs to shreds and scatter them across the Nine Provinces!"[739]

"…"

"…"

Jin Wikyung's fury did not subside until another day had passed.

"Mukyung and Taekyung left the Mount Heng Sword Sect yesterday?"

"Yes. So please take it down a notch."

"Are they both safe?"

"If they weren't, they'd be carried here on a cart. Why would they be riding in a carriage?"

"Then…"

"You should see them around noon tomorrow."

The thought that he could finally rest filled Wipeng with relief.

Who was he, after all? He was a Peak master known by the epithet Ghost Sword. He had the skill to secure an important position wherever he went, yet choosing the wrong lord had condemned him to this grueling labor.

When was the last time I had a drink?

Today, at last, he could enjoy some roast duck and a warm cup of liquor.

A satisfied smile had just appeared around Wipeng's lips when Jin Wikyung spoke.

"Good. Then let's hurry and get ready."

"Pardon? Get ready for what?"

"My brothers overcame countless hardships and successfully completed their mission. We have to hold a welcoming ceremony."

"…And what about me? Did I spend more than half a month touring the martial world for pleasure?"

"Hm? Who? Oh, you?"

Jin Wikyung blinked at Wipeng, then burst into hearty laughter.

"Of course that includes you! Surely you didn't think I'd forgotten?"

I'd thought surely not, but this guy had definitely forgotten.

As Wipeng stared at him in disbelief, opening and closing his mouth without a word, Jin Wikyung continued.

---

[739] The Nine Provinces is a traditional expression for the lands of China.

"Ah, have your men buy some cloth from a nearby fabric shop. As large as possible."

"Cloth? Why do we suddenly need that?"

"I have something in mind."

"…And that's what happened."

I glanced around as I listened to Wipeng, who looked ten years older than the last time I'd seen him.

We had reached Sakju two days after leaving the Mount Heng Sword Sect. The city was unexpectedly packed with people, and at the entrance, a gigantic white cloth bearing black writing fluttered in the wind.

Congratulations on the safe return of Jin Mukyung, Jin Taekyung, and Hyuk Mujin!

—Everyone in the Jin Family of Taiyuan—

A groan escaped me before I knew it.

"Oh, fuck. What the hell is that…?"

I had never seen anything like it in my life.

The banner's width alone was more than twenty jang—over sixty meters.[740] Strung between the tops of two pavilions facing each other across a broad avenue, it looked as though it might even be visible from the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

Look at that unnecessarily flamboyant calligraphy.

Even overbearing parents whose child had been accepted into a prestigious university wouldn't go this far.

Jin Mukyung, Hyuk Mujin, and I stared up at the banner with our mouths hanging open as if we had planned it.

"Why is my name so small?"

I looked again to see what he meant. Sure enough, even Hyuk Mujin's name had been included in tiny letters.

"Are you disappointed that the letters are small? I'd be happy if I were you."

"It looks strange. You can barely see my name from down here."

"Want to take my name out and put yours there instead? I mean it."

Hyuk Mujin considered the offer for a moment.

"Now that I think about it, it seems fine as it is."

"Then shut up."

"Yes, sir."

[740] A jang is a traditional Korean unit of length of about 3.03 m, or 9.94 ft. Twenty jang is about 60.6 m, or 199 ft.

That was as far as our conversation got. The overbearing parent—no, Jin Wikyung—came running toward us with the brightest smile in the world.

"You rascals!"

Was he a man or a brown bear?

The giant, well over two meters[741] tall, pulled Jin Mukyung and me close with hands the size of pot lids. His brute strength was so tremendous that it would not have been strange if he had crushed us to pieces.

"I'm so glad you're safe. Really, so glad!"

We had been safe.

Right up until Jin Wikyung hugged us with all his strength.

Crack.

"Guh!"

"Mukyung!"

…He doesn't look very safe now.

The perpetrator, still embracing his victim as he trembled in pain, shouted,

"Doctor! Doctor!"

"I think we should call a doctor. He looks like he's in real pain."

Wipeng answered me wearily.

"Is this your first day dealing with him? I knew this would happen, so I called one in advance."

"Ohhh."

It was the first time Wipeng had ever seemed magnificent.

The three Jin brothers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, including me, and Wipeng gathered together shortly after sunset.

When Jin Mukyung appeared wrapped in even thicker bandages, Jin Wikyung watched him apprehensively.

"Are you all right?"

"Would you be all right if it were you, my lord? How could you treat someone who was already injured so roughly?"

"I thought I was being gentle…"

Jin Wikyung might not have been the strongest in martial arts, but when it came to raw physical strength, he was Shanxi's Number One.

I quietly slid my chair farther away as Jin Mukyung answered with a haggard expression.

"I'm fine."

[741] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

"…"

He looked anything but fine.

It was fortunate that Jin Mukyung was a Peak master. An ordinary civilian who had never learned a single martial art wouldn't have been able to walk after that.

"I heard the Second Young Master had been injured, but I didn't realize it was this severe. Even his Internal Injury hasn't fully healed…"

"Did that Pung Yang bastard really do this to you?"

Jin Mukyung calmly nodded in response to their questions.

"He was strong. Stronger than I expected."

And who was Jin Mukyung? A promising young prodigy who had drawn the attention of the entire realm. Through dazzling talent and relentless effort, he had reached the Peak realm at an early age—yet he had been defeated by a mere mounted-bandit leader.

"You mean he was truly that powerful?"

"Pung Yang… I've heard that there are some fairly skilled masters among the mounted bandits of Gaoyuan. But still…"

Their gazes suddenly turned toward me.

The silent pressure told me to stop stuffing my face with roast duck and say something.

I swallowed the food filling my mouth and opened it.

"It's true. You've heard what happened to the Great Hero known as the Tiger of Mount Heng, right? His arms and legs got wrecked too. He's been getting around in a wheelchair lately."

"What is a wheelchair?"

"Ah, a cart. A cart."

Jin Wikyung tapped the table with one thick finger.

"A master of that caliber would have been known long ago. Mukyung, is it possible that you let your guard down?"

This time, Jin Mukyung shook his head without hesitation.

"I was caught by a move I hadn't anticipated, but that cannot be an excuse. Even if we fought again, the result would be the same."

"…He was that strong?"

"He used Body-Protecting Qi. It was overwhelming."

Jin Wikyung's and Wipeng's eyes widened simultaneously.

"Body-Protecting Qi!"

"Second Young Master, is that true?"

There was no need for an answer. Jin Mukyung had no reason to tell such an obvious lie. Facing their shock, he continued.

“He was the strongest opponent I’ve ever fought. No—to be precise, I should say he *became* that strong.”

“Became?”

“What do you mean by that…?”

“The instant he swallowed a blood-red pill, he became terrifyingly powerful.”

At last, the conversation had reached the Temporary Strength Pill.

I tried to act as naturally as possible.

I can’t let them find out I have it.

The Temporary Strength Pill was a poisoned chalice. It was undeniably ominous and suspicious, but its tremendous effects couldn’t be ignored.

I had already decided to use it as a second-worst contingency for the worst possible moment—when I was facing death.

“It was only for a brief moment, but when he was about to take the pill, I clearly saw that one pill remained inside the wooden case…”

Jin Mukyung trailed off and looked at me.

“Did you happen to find anything on Pung Yang’s person afterward?”

“Hm? Like what?”

“A wooden case. Or the red pill I mentioned.”

I deliberately furrowed my brow.

“I’m not sure. I searched him afterward to see if he had anything, but a bunch of wooden splinters spilled out. Maybe those were pieces of the case?”

“Then the pill? The pill?”

“No idea. I was half-dead myself. How was I supposed to search through everything?”

It was a fairly convincing excuse.

It wasn’t as though only one or two people had died, and the battle had been brutally fierce. It was only natural that I’d been too exhausted to search properly. What more could he say?

“Is that so?”

“The people from the Mount Heng Sword Sect might have found it. Or it could have dissolved into one of the countless pools of blood scattered across the ground.”

“Hmm.”

Jin Mukyung stared at me with faint suspicion, but I merely shrugged.

You won’t find it even if you search, idiot.

I had tucked it safely into a corner of the greatest vault in existence—my Inventory, which only I could open and close. Neither Jin Mukyung nor the greatest thief under heaven could touch a hair of the Temporary Strength Pill.

It really is convenient.

While I marveled once more at the convenience of the System, Jin Wikyung and Wipeng began speculating about the pill's origins.

"It must be a relic of demonic, heterodox arts. I remember hearing that quite a few pills with similar effects were used during the Great Faction War."

"Northern Shanxi, including Gaoyuan, once fell into the hands of the Demonic Cult. If Pung Yang discovered some remnant they left behind, it would make sense."

I had been listening with my ears perked up when I suddenly froze.

Wait. The Demonic Cult?

The Demonic Cult was a regular fixture you could never leave out of a Murim novel, the licorice in every medicine shop, and Geum Jandi's honorary firefighter.[742]

Of course, it wasn't a religious organization devoted to world peace and helping the poor. It was more like IS—the Islamic terrorist group.

In short, they were a bunch of fanatics you had absolutely nothing to gain from getting involved with.

What if the Demonic Cult made the Temporary Strength Pill?

Pung Yang's eyes had been stained red, like a demon that had just climbed out of hell. The pill had granted him unimaginable power, even if only temporarily.

I'm starting to see the picture.

This felt wrong. Really fucking wrong!

But nothing could be gained without suffering. The side effects should be something I could endure…

"The best-known pill used by the Demonic Cult at the time was the Blood-Exploding Pill, if memory serves."

"I've only heard stories about it. Don't all the blood vessels in the user's body burst after two shichen,[743] killing them?"

"That was the price of trying to gain power through dark arts."

"If the Blood-Exploding Pill was that terrible, just how severe would the side effects of Pung Yang's pill be?"

"I don't know, but they must be beyond imagination. It wouldn't just damage his innate qi. Once the time limit ended, his body would suffer tremendous strain. In the end, the pill uses the body itself as kindling and burns it for a brief period."

I swallowed dryly. Before I knew it, my voice had jumped out.

"And after that?"

---

[742] Geum Jandi is the heroine of the Korean drama *Boys Over Flowers*.

[743] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“It was made by the Demonic Cult. What else would you expect? Once the demonic qi surges into your very marrow… you’d become a murderous fiend who knows nothing but blood.”

“…A murderous fiend? The demonic qi surges into his marrow?”

“If an item like that fell into the hands of a villain, it would be a true disaster… Taekyung, what’s wrong?”

Jin Wikyung looked at me with concern. I rubbed my forehead and found it covered in beads of sweat.

“Nothing. I’m just a little hot.”

“What are you talking about? It’s snowing outside.”

“What would a Soeumin[744] know? I’m a Taeyangin.[745] That’s why…”

Damn it. I didn’t even know what I was saying anymore.

I gave the three of them an awkward smile.

“There’s something I forgot earlier.”

“…?”

“…?”

“…?”

“That pill. Now that I think about it, I have it. Heh-heh. Heh-heh-heh.”

“…!”

“…!”

“…!”

[744]Soeumin, or “lesser yin person,” is one of the four constitutional types in traditional Korean Sasang medicine.

[745]Taeyangin, or “greater yang person,” is another of the four constitutional types in Sasang medicine.

Chapter 127

It didn’t take long for the question marks to turn into exclamation points, and the exclamation points into bewilderment and rage.

Jin Mukyung was the first to break the silence.

“You…”

His face was flushed red, his breathing ragged. His fist twitched as if he wanted to plant one right in my mouth.

Well, he’s really pissed.

A chill ran through me. A dagger had flown in and lodged in my chest.

But don’t worry. I had a sturdy shield.

“Now, now, Mukyung.”

At the quiet voice, Jin Mukyung’s face twisted violently.

“Eldest brother!”

“Taekyung must have had his reasons. Isn’t that right?”

I deliberately lowered my eyes.

“No, eldest brother. I was shortsighted.”

“Hm?”

“I let my curiosity get the better of me… But after hearing what Eldest Brother said, I realized the truth. That object must never be kept—or hidden.”

I didn’t forget to make a show of trembling my fist, as if merely thinking about it made my teeth chatter with rage.

“The Demonic Cult! Just hearing the name of those vile bastards makes my teeth chatter with fury!”

That part was sincere. If they were going to make something, they should’ve made it properly. Turning the user into a deranged murderer was one hell of a design flaw.

“Good heavens.”

Jin Wikyung looked at me with eyes full of affection.

“I remember a small, adorable little boy who said he would grow up to become a chivalrous hero. You were six years old then. Do you remember?”

Of course I didn’t.

Even the year before last was already hazy. How was I supposed to know what the original owner of this body had done at age six?

Still, I nodded solemnly.

“I remember it clearly. It was my one and only dream.”

Chivalrous hero, governor of Gyeonggi Province[746]—whatever. As of this moment, that was my career aspiration at age six.

"Ha-ha. To think that little boy would grow into such a fine man."

Jin Wikyung smiled with satisfaction, then turned to the other two.

"You were there too, Wipeng. Do you remember?"

Wipeng answered without even taking a breath.

"I don't remember that, but I do remember him starting to womanize exactly ten years later. When I asked what he wanted to be when he grew up, he said he'd become the greatest ladies' man under heaven."

"A hero ought to know how to enjoy romance."

"He doesn't know squat about martial arts, so what good is knowing about romance? Is the hero you're talking about a hero of the night, a hero to courtesans, or something?"

"Be quiet. Our youngest showed unusual promise from an early age."

"So that promise… Ah, forget it. I should just keep my mouth shut."

Glug, glug.

Jin Wikyung neatly ignored Wipeng, who was pouring liquor straight from the bottle, and turned to the next man in line.

"Mukyung. Now that you understand your little brother's sincerity, let go of your anger."

Jin Mukyung, whose face was twisted into an ugly grimace, finally spoke.

"Can't I hit that bastard just once?"

"Now, now."

"Just once. Please."

At the icy voice, I quickly bowed my head.

"Please forgive this foolish little brother, Second Brother."

"You've been talking down to me this whole time, and now you're calling me 'brother'?"

"Pardon? Me?"

"That's enough. This is your final warning."

"No. Hit me instead. If that would ease your anger, this little brother will gladly endure it."

"You little shit!"

Jin Mukyung shot to his feet, only to sink back down with a gasp. The bandages wrapped around his chest were turning red. His wound must have reopened.

"Oh, no! Second Brother, are you all right?"

"This bastard, again… Guh!"

[746] In Korean, the phrases for "chivalrous hero" (*hyeopui jisa*) and "governor of Gyeonggi Province" (*Gyeonggi-do jisa*) share the sound *jisa*.

“Doctor! Doctor!”

The drinking party descended into chaos in an instant.

Wipeng silently picked up his second bottle and muttered,

“This family is really something…”

And how something it was—the foremost family in Shanxi.

The atmosphere finally settled down after the physician had come and gone.

Ignoring Jin Mukyung’s murderous glare, I took the Temporary Strength Pill from inside my robes.

“This is it.”

The pill was entirely red, as if blood had been condensed into a single sphere.

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng examined it closely.

“Wipeng, what do you think?”

“Just looking at it, I can smell blood. It’s a vicious object.”

“Could it really have been made by the Demonic Cult?”

“I couldn’t say. If it were, we should be able to sense demonic qi… but I can’t be certain.”

“Right? There’s something different about it.”

Both of them looked extremely serious. I was just as curious about where the Temporary Strength Pill had come from and who had made it, so I decided to give them a hint.

“They called it a Temporary Strength Pill.”

“A Temporary Strength Pill?”

“Yes. I heard it directly from Pung Yang’s own mouth.”

Jin Mukyung abruptly cut in.

“Pung Yang? When?”

“While you were unconscious.”

“…Hoo. Hoo…”

No matter what anyone said, I was the sole eyewitness and witness. While Jin Mukyung steadied his breathing to calm himself after getting nowhere, the furrows between the other two men’s brows only deepened.

“A Temporary Strength Pill, Wipeng?”

“I’ve never heard the name either. If something this potent belonged to the Demonic Cult, it must have been used during the Great Faction War…”

“What if the Demonic Cult didn’t make it?”

Their gazes turned toward me.

“Not the Demonic Cult?”

"What makes you think that?"

"I'm just saying there's no need to jump to conclusions."

In truth, I had said it out of hope that I might be able to take the pill back if it hadn't been made by the Demonic Cult.

Of course, I had another thought as well.

The Head Elder.

On the surface, the enemy in the last battle had clearly been the Mount Heng Sword Sect. But the true enemy had been the Head Elder himself.

Rather than making a simple either-or assumption, I believed we always had to keep open the possibility that there might be a third faction involved.

"Well, it just suddenly occurred to me."

After hearing me out, the other two men's expressions grew strange. Then, in the next moment, a very quiet voice escaped Wipeng's lips.

It was a single word that slipped out unconsciously, like a groan.

"Dark Heaven…"

"Wipeng."

Jin Wikyung's sharp gaze cut off whatever he had been about to say.

"Ah, I apologize. I misspoke."

Wipeng hurriedly tried to cover it up.

But it was already too late.

The two words *Dark Heaven* had been deeply etched into my mind.

Dark Heaven? What's that?

Then something unexpected happened.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have obtained a small amount of information about Dark Heaven.
The item description for the Temporary Strength Pill will be updated.

The System notification had come out of nowhere. I held out my hand toward Wipeng, who was holding the Temporary Strength Pill.

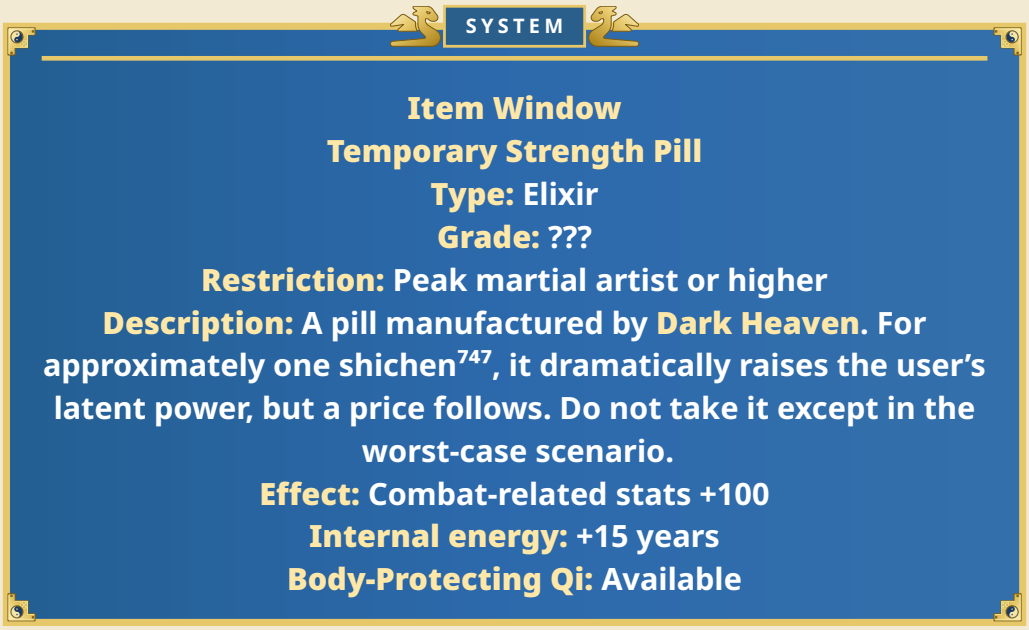
"May I take a quick look?"

"Of course."

Item check.

The moment I muttered the command in my head, the information on the Temporary Strength Pill appeared.

The change was easy to spot.



The phrase *Someone Unknown* had disappeared, replaced by the unfamiliar term *Dark Heaven*.

Judging by the context, it's definitely some kind of organization…

Well, anyone capable of making something like the Temporary Strength Pill was bound to be no better than the Demonic Cult. Same rotten lot, different name.

Dark Heaven.

Whoever had named them had one hell of a gift. Those two words alone announced that they were shady bastards.

These fuckers definitely have something rotten going on behind the scenes. I'm ninety-nine percent sure.

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng seem to know something.

The problem was that, judging by their reactions, they were extremely reluctant to reveal anything about Dark Heaven.

Should I poke at them once?

But before I could open my mouth, Jin Mukyung beat me to it.

"Dark Heaven? What is that?"

"Well…"

A troubled look crossed Jin Wikyung's face.

"I'm sorry. I can't tell you yet."

Those words came from a man who cared deeply for his younger brothers.

If even Jin Wikyung refused to speak, there was no point asking Wipeng.

[747] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

"I apologize, Young Masters, but I cannot tell you until the matter becomes clearer."

His attitude was firmer than I had ever seen it. Jin Mukyung and I both realized that we had to withdraw for today.

But the more they tried to hide it, the more curious I became about Dark Heaven.

So it's a secret they have to keep even from us.

Setting aside the fact that Mukyung and I were direct descendants, we were both core masters of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. If Wipeng was Jin Wikyung's right arm, either of us could more than qualify as his left arm—or at least one of his legs.

Then it must be top-secret information known only to those two, even within the family.

I was only human, so I couldn't help being curious. The fact that the System had reacted this time, despite remaining silent during the Mount Heng Sword Sect incident, also played a part.

Dark Heaven. The Temporary Strength Pill. A top-secret matter known only to Jin Wikyung and Wipeng.

Several keywords flashed through my mind.

All right. I'd made up my mind.

I'll ignore it and go on living.

Too much curiosity had a way of shortening your life. It had only been a few days since I'd gone to deliver the mail to the Mount Heng Sword Sect and nearly died.

A mysterious organization whose very name was ominous? If I got involved with them, it was obvious things wouldn't end well.

"Come now, let's stop talking about this and have another drink."

Jin Wikyung forced the mood back to normal.

Wipeng had already demolished two bottles by himself, and even the injured Mukyung was filling his glass. How could I be the only one to sit out? I accepted the liquor Jin Wikyung poured and downed it in one gulp.

Gulp, gulp.

The notoriously potent fire liquor burned down my throat in a rush of heat.

"Guhhh."

Wow. This was no joke.

I knew it was strong, but drinking it myself, it was far more potent than I'd expected. At this strength, soju[748] and beer couldn't even hold a candle to it.

Unlike me, who shuddered from head to toe, the other three immediately filled their empty glasses to the brim.

"Drink!"

"Pour it down!"

[748] *Soju* is a Korean distilled spirit commonly made from grains or starches.

“Keep going till we drop!”

“…”

It wasn’t until we had drunk through the entire night that I learned Shanxi Province was part of North China—and that every man from North China was an incredible drinker.

At noon the next day, I mounted my horse in a perfectly refreshed mood, and Hyuk Mujin stared at me as if I were a monster.

“Is your stomach all right?”

“Yeah. It’s fine.”

“Don’t tell me you were the only one who didn’t drink last night. Or did you fall asleep halfway through?”

“No. The four of us kept drinking.”

“…All of it?”

His mouth fell open.

“How is that possible? Are you even human?”

“It all went down.”

“Good heavens. How many bottles did you drink through the night?”

He had the wrong unit.

Not bottles. Barrels.

We kept emptying massive casks of liquor—the kind I’d only ever seen in pirate movies—and then emptying more.

“I think it was close to twenty barrels. I stopped counting after ten, so I’m not sure.”

“Wow. That’s incredible.”

Hyuk Mujin raised his thumb in admiration. Just then, the inn door swung open.

And three zombies—or rather, three Peak masters—emerged.

“Uuugh.”

“Urk.”

“Huff, huff.”

Pale faces, parched lips, and hollow eyes.

Every last one of them dragged his feet straight into the carriage. The martial artists of the escort force stared wide-eyed.

“Why are they suddenly getting into the carriage…?”

“They look really unwell.”

“That can’t be right. Haven’t you ever drunk with our Commander? Wipeng, the God of Drinking? Never heard of him?”

“Wasn’t the Commander’s epithet Ghost Sword?”

“Whatever else you might say, when it comes to drinking, he could probably beat even the Martial God. They’re probably just like this because all the fatigue they’ve accumulated finally caught up with them.”

As the martial artists whispered among themselves, the carriage door suddenly flew open, and one person hurriedly dashed out and bent over.

“Urrp, buuurrgh!”

Splaaarsh.

Wipeng spent a good while spewing nothing but pale liquid, then staggered back into the carriage. One of the martial artists who had been talking animatedly muttered in a dazed voice,

“…This can’t be.”

“It absolutely can. Anyone can see that’s a hangover. They drank like that all night without sleeping. Of course they’d end up like that.”

“Then why is the Third Young Master so perfectly fine?”

Every eye in the escort force turned toward me.

The smell of liquor radiating from my entire body was strong enough to send chills down the spine. But in complete contrast, my face looked unbelievably refreshed, and my breathing was calm.

“No way…”

“The Third Young Master beat the Commander? That God of Drinking?”

A buzz spread through the crowd.

Hyuk Mujin’s look of admiration had gone beyond admiration and become outright reverence.

“Ah, I knew it! That’s our Captain—the man who used to drink with courtesans every damn day!”

“…”

“I remember what the Chief Steward said. If Captain had kept drinking for three more years, he would have uprooted our family’s entire foundation. So that’s why you always had to steal from the family coffers!”

“…Hey, you punk.”

We weren’t alone. What did he think would happen to my image if he talked like that?

As if the stares pouring in from every direction hadn’t already made my face feel hot enough.

“Ahem. Ahem!”

I cleared my throat and glanced around. And what do you know? The eyes of all those rough-looking men were sparkling brighter than stars in the night sky.

“The true God of Drinking. That’s him.”

“He’s famous in Taiyuan’s red-light district. Haven’t you heard of the Night King?”

“The Night King? The epithet says it all. So he was already renowned for his drinking.”

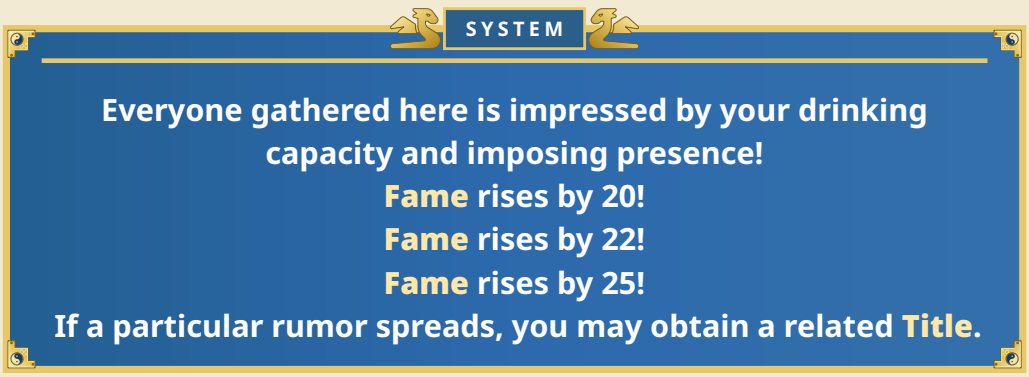
“No, not that… You know. That.”

“Gasp. Is it true?”

“How would I know? I’ve never seen it.”

“Turns out he’s a true man among men.”

Ding.



“…”

Why the fuck was my Fame shooting up?

And what was this about a related Title? No, thanks. Put it away. Please, just let me be satisfied with the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

Stop it, you lunatics…

I turned away in inexplicable shame—only to find Hyuk Mujin staring intently at a certain part of my body.

“…What are you doing?”

“Oh, I was just measuring it by eye.”

He answered so matter-of-factly that I was almost thrown off. Hyuk Mujin held out his forearm with an innocent smile.

“Wow. As expected, you’re amazing. Hehe.”

In return for his forearm, I offered him my fist.

Thwack!

Chapter 128

Old Man Jang woke to the sound of a commotion.

What goddamn bastards are making all that noise?

He was already sleeping less and less with age, so he wasn't happy about being woken.

Let's see what these bastards' faces look like.

Dragging his stiff body out of the thatched cottage, Old Man Jang immediately spotted a crowd gathered like clouds.

There were hundreds of them, by his rough estimate. It looked as if everything in the village with legs—human or animal—had gathered in one place.

"What's all this about?"

It was a small, unremarkable village, so he knew most of the faces.

At Old Man Jang's muttering, a market merchant he recognized greeted him.

"You're awake, sir."

"With this kind of racket, how could I stay asleep?"

"Ha-ha, please understand, sir. Everyone's gathered because they heard an important guest was coming."

Old Man Jang grunted.

"An important guest? Is the Emperor coming?"

"Oh, there you go again. Is the Emperor your friend?"

"Going by age, I'd be his father."

"You'll get arrested for treason talking like that. Can't you see the government troops over there?"

"Government troops?"

Following the merchant's nod, Old Man Jang spotted dozens of government troops and the county magistrate dressed in his official robes. His eyes narrowed.

"That fellow never showed his face when the mounted bandits were prowling around, but now he's even put on his official robes? Is this important guest some high-ranking official?"

"Not a high-ranking official, but in Shanxi Province, they're number one."

The merchant raised his thumb.

At that very moment, excited shouts erupted from the assembled crowd.

"They're coming!"

"They're here!"

Old Man Jang turned to follow everyone's gaze. When he saw fifty mounted riders galloping toward them in the distance, their flags snapping in the wind, he finally realized who the important guests were.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Old Man Jang had little interest in the affairs of the world, but even he had heard the name of the Jin Family of Taiyuan until his ears rang.

A prestigious family that had maintained its lineage for three hundred years, and the hegemon that held Shanxi Province in its grasp.

As Old Man Jang watched the imposing procession, his brow suddenly furrowed.

Who was that fellow again? That… what was it? Shanxi, Shanxi… some kind of dragon?

Age had weakened his memory as well. As Old Man Jang lamented the passing years, one person caught his eye.

"Say, who's that young man?"

"Ah, that Young Hero?"

There were dozens of martial artists from the Jin Family of Taiyuan alone, all clearly visible. Yet the merchant immediately understood whom he meant.

An awl in a pocket. The young man's presence was like an awl tucked inside a pouch, bound to stand out wherever he went, so there was nothing strange about it.

"That's the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

Shing—

As if he had heard those words, the young man at the head of the procession drew the sword at his waist.

The transparent blade flashed in the sunlight, and a thunderous cheer erupted.

"Waaaaaah!"

"Jin Family of Taiyuan! Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Heaven Shaking Sword!"

"Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Jin Taekyung! Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Jin Taekyung!"

My epithet and name rang out from every direction. Even though I'd already experienced this several times over the past few days, it still filled me with pride.

Is this how idols feel?

This was that thing, wasn't it? *Milky-skinned Jin Taekyung. We love you, Jin Taekyung.*

An idol fan club, the kind I'd only ever seen on music variety shows, was right in front of me. Smiling contentedly, I drew the [Unnamed Sword] from my waist.

Shhhng. Flash!

Maybe it was the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron brand, but nothing else came close when it came to visual effects.

"Waaaaaah!"

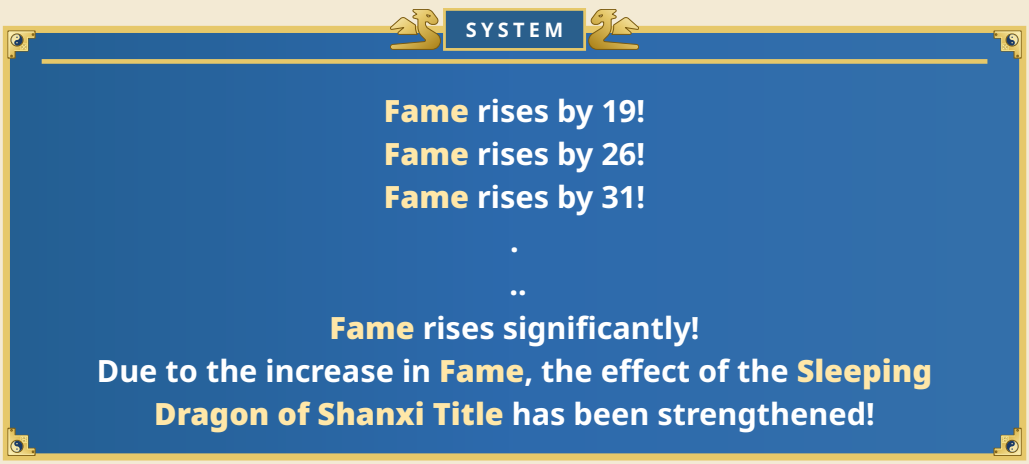
“Eeeeek! Young Master, take me!”

“Wah! Wah!”

A man for everyone, like something rated for all audiences—men and women, young and old.

That man was me.

Ding.



The Title effect has been strengthened?

That was an unexpected bonus. I opened my Status Window to check the changes.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 61 Jin Taekyung
Class: First Rate Martial Artist
Fame: 2,100 (+250)
Titles: 4 (Title effects active)
— Returnee (All stats +10)
— Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi (All stats +15, Fame +200)
— Scion of a Prestigious Family (All stats +5, Fame +50)
— Gambler (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one combat)
Strength: 196 (+30)
Stamina: 195 (+30)
Agility: 192 (+30)
Intelligence: 35 (+30)
Charm: 35 (+30)
Internal Energy: 45 years
Toughness: 155 (+30)
Remaining Points: 60
— Distribute your remaining points.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi's Title effect had definitely changed. Before, it had granted All stats +10 and Fame +100.

So my name carries more weight now?

Titles didn't simply drop from the heavens.

In my case, rumors about me being some kind of sleeping dragon had gradually spread, and at some point, my Fame rose and I gained the Title Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

It seemed that a Title's effect increased as Fame rose.

My Level has already passed sixty, too.

The Status Window, which I hadn't checked in a while, had grown by leaps and bounds. My Fame had shot up, my combat-related stats were approaching 200, and I had a solid forty-five years of internal energy.

Now that's the stuff! Innkeeper!

I shuddered with exhilaration, and Hyuk Mujin, who was carrying a flag to my right, looked at me as though I were mentally ill.

"Are you really that happy?"

I deliberately put on a serious face.

"Who said I was happy? The people were enjoying themselves, so I was just livening up the mood."

"…I have a lot to say, but I won't."

"Wise choice."

As we rode amid the crowd's cheers, we pulled on the reins and slowed down.

Dozens of men had poured out into the street and blocked our path.

Among them, a fat man dressed in splendid red robes smiled broadly at me.

"Heh-heh, you're every bit as dignified and handsome as I'd heard. I've long been familiar with the great reputation of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

"Ah, yes."

Confused, I asked, "But who are you?"

Hyuk Mujin hurriedly whispered, "He's the county magistrate. The county magistrate."

"What's a county magistrate?"

"What? You don't even know what a county magistrate is?"

"Is he like a village head?"

"Wow, this is driving me crazy. Just think of him as an official."

"An official. Then are the people behind him government troops?"

"…Why are you acting like you've never seen government troops before?"

"No, I just find it interesting."

In fact, I really had never seen them before.

I studied the fat man—no, the county magistrate—and his subordinates carefully.

I knew that this world had a government, official offices, and law-enforcement agencies, but this was the first time I'd actually encountered them.

How could they never show even the tips of their noses?

Violent crimes happened dozens of times a day around here, yet I had never once seen government troops drag away a criminal.

Then again, considering the authorities hadn't intervened in the Battle of Eight Spring Gorge, where roughly two thousand people had clashed, or in this latest incident involving the Red Wind Band, perhaps that was only natural.

It's not as if they're even beating up the mounted bandits who loiter around.

What exactly did these bastards do?

I was imagining that, if this were modern times, half the martial artists in the Murim would be locked in solitary confinement for murder when the county magistrate cleared his throat.

"Ahem. Ahem!"

His face flushed red as he coughed awkwardly.

He was an official of some standing, after all, and seemed offended that I had ignored him.

"Oh, I'm sorry. I injured my head a while ago, so I keep spacing out."

I'd only offered a reasonable excuse, but the county magistrate's expression finally relaxed a little.

"Ahem, no, no. You must have endured great hardship dealing with those vicious mounted bandits. Ah, I heard you killed more than five hundred of them?"

"Uh… five hundred?"

"That's right. I was overjoyed to hear the tales of valor of the two heroes, the Heaven Shaking Sword and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. Ha-ha."

I had no idea where that number had come from.

Even if you counted every mounted bandit who took part in the battle, there might have been three hundred at most. And by the time Jin Mukyung and I arrived, fewer than a hundred of them remained.

In reality, there was Pung Yang and maybe seventy mounted bandits who were already exhausted. Something like that.

Well, rumors were usually exaggerated.

"Come on, that's too—"

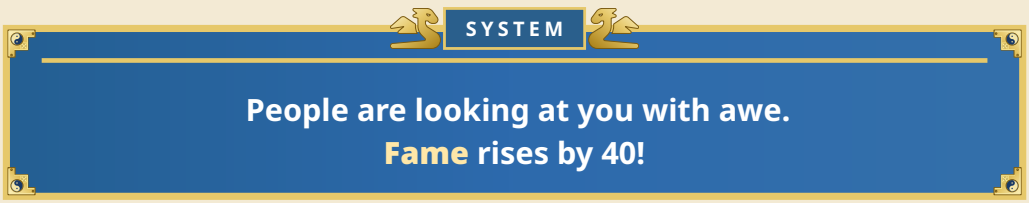
Just as I was about to tell him the truth, murmurs spread through the people who had been listening to my conversation with the county magistrate.

"Five hundred? Didn't the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi and the Heaven Shaking Sword go there alone?"

"Good heavens. The two of them defeated more than five hundred mounted bandits?"

"How can human beings be that strong?"

Ding.



"Too what, did you say?"

I continued speaking to the bewildered county magistrate.

"That's far too low. In reality, there were nearly six hundred."

"Six hundred!"

"My second brother and I took half each."

"Then three hundred each!"

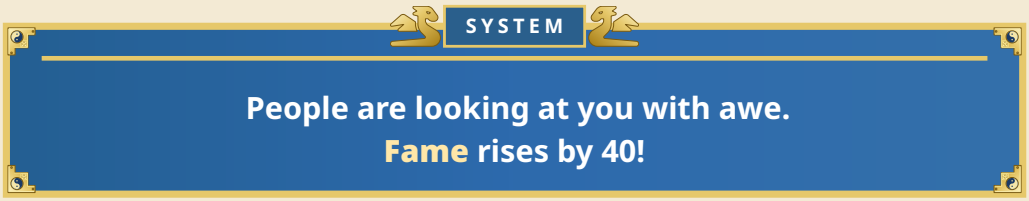
"Hmm. More precisely, about 285?"

The county magistrate—and even the government troops—gaped at me.

"Ooh!"

"Two hundred and eighty-five! He even knows the exact number!"

Ding.



This time, Hyuk Mujin whispered to me with an expression usually reserved for looking at a bug.

“Do you really want to take it this far?”

“Yep.”

“What are you going to do if you inflate your achievements for no reason and get caught lying?”

“You, Wolhwa, and the Mount Heng Sword Sect just have to keep your mouths shut. So hurry up and back me up.”

“I refuse. Hyuk Mujin may not look it, but I’ve lived a truthful life without a single shameful moment before the heavens.”

I stared at him in disbelief.

“When Jin Mukyung destroyed my pavilion, weren’t you the one who fought assassins that didn’t even exist?”

“…”

“If you have nothing to say, shut up and watch your expression. My two hundred and eighty… How many was it?”

“Two hundred and eighty-five.”

“Right. I’ll say you took care of about thirty of them. If you were born with balls, you ought to become Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion in the Jin Family of Taiyuan at least once in your life. Don’t you think?”

“…!”

Hyuk Mujin, who had lived a truthful life without a single shameful moment before the heavens, used dazzling verbal footwork to completely win over the county magistrate.

The mounted bandits, most of whom had been Second Rate or Third Rate, became First Rate masters to a man—each a Lü Bu[749] astride Red Hare.[750] Pung Yang became an invincible master who could cleave mountains and seas with a single sword strike.

From now on, I’m filtering anything that comes out of this bastard’s mouth.

He was such a skilled liar that even I found myself wondering whether it was true. If even I, the person involved, was confused, there was no hope for anyone else.

---

[749] Lü Bu was a warrior and military commander of China’s Three Kingdoms era, famed for his fighting ability.

[750] Red Hare was a celebrated horse associated with Lü Bu in the Three Kingdoms tradition.

"…and that was how Pung Yang, the absolute ruler of Gaoyuan, and the vicious Red Wind Band came to meet their end at the Mount Heng Sword Sect."

The moment Hyuk Mujin finished his bullshit—his story, I mean—sighs of disappointment rose from all around us. The county magistrate's reaction was the most enthusiastic of all.

"Whaaaat? How could such a thing happen? The Murim is truly a wondrous yet terrifying place."

Hyuk Mujin swept his gaze over the crowd with melancholy eyes.

"A martial brute like me has no fear. Ever since I took up the sword, I've lived with death as my companion. But if I have one wish…"

"One wish?"

"To die by the sword of someone strong. That is all I could ask for."

"…"

What a bumper crop of bullshit.

Suppressing the urge to smack Hyuk Mujin in the back of the head, I stepped forward.

I had already milked the Fame for all it was worth, and it wasn't rising anymore. There was no reason to keep talking to a potbellied middle-aged man.

"Sorry to interrupt, but we're in a hurry."

The county magistrate, who had been gazing at Hyuk Mujin with dazed eyes as if hypnotized, suddenly came to his senses.

"Ah, my apologies. I didn't mean for this to happen."

"Then did you have some other business?"

"Could I meet Great Hero Jin? The Lesser Family Head, I mean."

The county magistrate's gaze shifted toward the carriage behind me.

They couldn't be seen from outside, but Jin Wikyung, Jin Mukyung, and Wipeng were inside.

Because they were drunk out of their minds.

They were the losers who had been utterly crushed by me in our drinking contest over the past three days. But how could I tell him the truth? Without so much as changing my expression, I lied.

"I'm sorry, but he's currently circulating his qi, so I don't think he can see you. As you know, County Magistrate, it's quite dangerous."

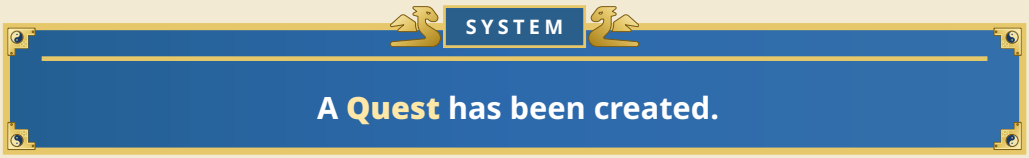
"Ah, I see. Then it can't be helped."

The county magistrate clicked his tongue, then pulled a tightly rolled piece of paper from his sleeve and handed it to me.

"What is this?"

“An invitation from the City Lord. After hearing about your recent exploits, Young Hero Jin, he seems to have been deeply impressed, so he arranged a gathering with several young prodigies.”

Ding.



Chapter 129

Ding.

SYSTEM

A Quest has been created.
Quest
The City Lord's Invitation
High renown is bound to attract attention.
The City Lord of Shanxi Province, having heard rumors about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, invites you to a luncheon with several young prodigies tomorrow.
Grade: Third Rate
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Objective: Attend the luncheon hosted by the City Lord (Incomplete)
Reward: Varies according to the City Lord's reaction.
Failure: The City Lord becomes extremely depressed.
Would you like to accept the Quest?
Y / N
※ If you reject the Quest, the City Lord may sulk.

The City Lord wants me?

It was certainly unexpected, but not all that surprising. Politicians often made use of other people's fame, after all.

Of course, this was a world where media had almost no reach, so personal curiosity was probably the greater factor.

But…

What do you mean, the City Lord might sulk if I reject the Quest?

What was there to sulk about? Imagining a middle-aged man with five folds under his chin sulking sent goose bumps all over my body.

"Young Hero?"

Pretending not to notice the county magistrate's puzzled expression, I scratched my chin.

Hmm. What a pain.

It was only a Third Rate Quest. The EXP and Fame I could gain would probably be minimal, and I'd have to carefully flatter the City Lord to obtain the reward.

Wouldn't I be better off spending that time practicing martial arts?

It's not like I have to come running the instant the City Lord calls.

I was on my way back after a battle in which I had nearly lost my life. I didn't particularly want to have lunch tomorrow with some middle-aged man called the City Lord whose face I had never even seen.

If I rejected the Quest, the worst that could happen was that he'd sulk. Whatever. Let him sulk all he wanted.

I was just about to turn him down as politely as possible when—

Snatch.

"We'll go. Absolutely!"

Hyuk Mujin suddenly stepped forward and grabbed the invitation. The county magistrate frowned.

"I don't believe I invited you."

His voice had turned cold. Hyuk Mujin didn't care in the slightest and flashed him a shameless smile.

"Oh my, of course not. It's just that our Young Master has always respected the City Lord so deeply that he was too moved to speak."

The county magistrate stared at me through narrowed eyes.

"Hmm. Is that true?"

Of course it wasn't.

I was about to say so when Hyuk Mujin turned his back to the county magistrate and silently mouthed at me.

You absolutely have to go?

Unlike usual, he looked strangely desperate.

I made a quick decision.

"Of course. Is there anyone in Shanxi who doesn't respect the City Lord?"

"Ha-ha, spoken like a true citizen of a Great Nation. The City Lord will be delighted to hear it."

Only then did the county magistrate's expression soften into a satisfied smile. He turned around.

"Then I'll take that as your acceptance and be on my way. Please convey my regards to the Lesser Family Head and the Heaven Shaking Sword as well."

"Ah, of course."

Ding.

The System notification rang out.

Now I can't even cancel it.

Once the county magistrate and the government troops had moved away, I pressed my foot down on Hyuk Mujin's and whispered,

"I think you have something to tell me. Don't you?"

"I'll explain. Let's get out of here first."

There were still too many eyes watching us. Amid the people's cheers, we mounted our horses again.

We continued farther into the village until we reached our destination. A little errand boy shot out like a bullet and bowed at the waist.

"Welcome—gasp."

The fifty mounted riders and the escort force's intimidating presence startled him once. Recognizing Hyuk Mujin and me startled him a second time.

He was the errand boy from the Phoenix Inn. I had seen him a few days ago.

"The private annex is fifty silver nyang a night. Right?"

"Uh, you're the one from back then?"

"Hey, you little brat. How dare you point at a guest as lofty as the heavens?"

After sternly scolding the boy, Hyuk Mujin tossed him a heavy money pouch.

The little boy glanced nervously between us, then sucked in a breath when he saw the pouch packed with silver.

"Gasp. Th-this much?"

"From this moment on, the Jin Family of Taiyuan is taking over the Phoenix Inn."

"…Are you some kind of two-knife gangster?"

Anyone watching would have thought we were members of organized crime.

The three zombies climbed out of the carriage and began frantically gulping down the broth first the moment the food arrived.

It was understandable, considering they had spent three days drinking to excess without taking a single day off. No—if they hadn't practiced martial arts, they might have died of alcohol poisoning on the first day.

"Guhhh, I feel alive again."

The instant Jin Wikyung leaned back in his chair after finishing his hangover cure, Wipeng's nagging flew at him.

"My lord, please maintain your dignity. Your dignity."

"What does it matter? We're the only ones here."

"Even so, what will your subordinates think if you keep letting them see you like this?"

"It's fine. I didn't throw up."

That single sentence silenced Wipeng. Jin Wikyung then turned to me.

“So, the county magistrate came by?”

“Yes. He said the City Lord was inviting me to a luncheon tomorrow.”

“The City Lord?”

“I don’t know why, but he seemed interested in me. I was planning to reject it, but some thoughtless idiot accepted it without hesitation.”

“Did he? Who on earth would do that?”

Hyuk Mujin, who had been sitting in the corner of the table and nervously watching our expressions, answered in a tiny voice.

“That would be me, Lesser Family Head.”

“Ah, I see. You’re the fellow they call our youngest brother’s right-hand man. The one who served at the Gate Guard Pavilion until recently. Your name was… Hyuk Mujin, wasn’t it?”

Compared to the modern world, the Jin Family of Taiyuan was a conglomerate, while Jin Wikyung was the chairman’s eldest son and the actual head of the company.

Assistant Manager Hyuk, who had spent every day getting bullied by his foul-tempered boss, answered in a deeply moved voice.

“Ah, thank you for remembering me.”

“I should be thanking you. Our youngest brother still has some rough edges, so keep helping him as you did today.”

“A-as you command!”

“Ha-ha. It’s good to see such spirit.”

Jin Wikyung laughed cheerfully, then turned back to me.

“Accepting the City Lord’s invitation was absolutely the right thing to do.”

“Really? From what I’ve experienced so far, he doesn’t seem to have much to do with the Murim.”

“For a long time, the government and the Murim have maintained a relationship of noninterference. Do you know that?”

“Yes, more or less.”

I had learned about the Murim through novels. The common conventions of martial-arts fiction weren’t all that different from how things worked here.

“They recognize each other’s domains, but nothing good can come from offending the government. The Murim is only one part of the world. The world itself is not the Murim.”

Jin Wikyung pointed to the bowl in front of him. It was half-filled with broth and contained one large chunk of meat.

“Do you understand what I mean?”

I nodded.

The bowl was the world, and the chunk of meat inside it was the Murim.

“We are martial artists, but it is the Emperor who rules the world. Among the people, the authority of the Son of Heaven is absolute. The City Lords govern their respective provinces under the Emperor’s command, so they possess considerable power and authority.”

“More than the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“In terms of authority alone, yes. We simply acknowledge and respect each other’s power. Murim sects sometimes maintain public order where the government cannot, and they also send martial arts instructors to train government troops. The government provides assistance in return. The two sides help each other.”

So the government and the Murim were like the crocodile and the crocodile bird.

After thinking for a moment, I voiced the question that had been nagging at me since earlier.

“Then why does the government sit back and do nothing when mounted bandits run wild or large-scale battles break out between sects? I can understand staying out of the last war because it was a matter between martial artists, but the mounted bandits are different, aren’t they?”

Even Lee Cheonbaek had massacred everyone at the Sakju Branch and committed the insane act of killing children, but the victims had belonged to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Strictly speaking, they could be considered people who had been sacrificed to the gratitude and grudges between Murim sects.

But the mounted bandits killed indiscriminately and burned everything in their path without any of that, didn’t they?

To mounted bandits, commoners are easy prey.

Weak before the strong and strong before the weak. That was what mounted bandits were.

The important point was that I had encountered dozens of mounted bandits on the way to the Mount Heng Sword Sect, yet I hadn’t even seen a government soldier.

“That’s…”

Jin Wikyung let his voice trail off. Jin Mukyung, who had been silently inhaling his food until then, suddenly blurted,

“Because the City Lord is incompetent. No, in this case, is the Emperor incompetent?”

The moment he finished speaking, Hyuk Mujin had a fit, while Jin Wikyung and Wipeng deliberately hardened their expressions.

“Hey, Mukyung.”

“It’s just us here. No one can overhear us. Besides, I didn’t say anything untrue.”

“Second Young Master, our family does not yet stand alongside the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families. Please refrain from saying anything that could cause trouble.”

I asked Jin Mukyung, who reluctantly nodded.

“What do you mean, the City Lord is incompetent?”

“Do you not know what the word *incompetent* means?”

“Should I report you to the authorities for insulting the Emperor?”

“Treason gets at least three clans[751] punished. Congratulations, little brother.”

This bastard Jin Mukyung has gotten pretty good with words.

“Do you know who the current City Lord is?”

“Kim Chunbae?”

“…If you don’t know, just say you don’t know.”

He looked at me as if I were a bug, then continued.

“The current City Lord of Shanxi has the surname Zhu.”

“So?”

“What do you mean, *so*? He’s a member of the imperial family. The imperial family!”

“Oh, really?”

Apparently, this was a Zhu dynasty. In the span of a moment, I had been branded an ignorant fool who didn’t even know the Emperor’s surname.

Still, it wasn’t as if this sort of thing had only happened once or twice. I wasn’t even embarrassed anymore.

“Fine, I get it. Keep going.”

Jin Mukyung let out a deep sigh and continued.

“The current City Lord is the Emperor’s youngest brother, and his imperial title is Prince. As a direct member of the imperial family, he stands on a different level from the other City Lords. He’s someone whose invitation we must accept, even if we have to force ourselves, if only to preserve his dignity.”

“Oh.”

He really was on a different level. Not just an ordinary City Lord, but the Emperor’s brother. An actual king, no less.

Born the son of the Son of Heaven and then becoming the younger brother of the Son of Heaven, he hadn’t merely been born with a silver spoon in his mouth. His spoon was made of vibranium.

He was the modern North Korean nuclear spoon[752]—and then some.

“Then how can someone who’s practically a king be so incompetent? One letter to his brother should get him all the support he needs from above. Are they on bad terms?”

---

[751] “Three clans” refers to a form of collective punishment that could extend a person’s sentence to their relatives.

[752] Korean “spoon” slang describes the social standing someone inherits at birth. A “nuclear spoon” suggests a status beyond even a gold spoon; the comparison invokes North Korea’s ruling family.

“Who knows? I don’t know the details of that family’s affairs, but I doubt they’re particularly close. There are rumors that the current Emperor assassinated the Crown Prince, his immediately older brother, before ascending the throne.”

“Talk about a hunger for power.”

“People kill over a single dumpling. Imagine what they’d do for the imperial throne.”

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng’s mouths fell open, while Hyuk Mujin had another fit.

“Your Honor, I didn’t hear anything. I truly know nothing. In fact, I haven’t been able to hear for a long time…”

As Hyuk Mujin muttered like a madman, Jin Mukyung smacked him across the back of the head. I asked,

“Does he not get any support because he’s on bad terms with the Emperor? Or is he simply lost in wine and women?”

“Wine? Women?”

Jin Mukyung gave another short laugh.

“He’s only ten years old. It’s too early for him to lose himself in wine and women.”

“What, ten? You mean a ten-year-old is the City Lord?”

“He’s a direct member of the imperial family. With his bloodline, he could become far more than a City Lord.”

The System message I’d seen earlier suddenly came to mind.

> ※ If you reject the Quest, the City Lord may sulk.

I had thought it was ridiculous for a middle-aged man to act so childish, but now that I knew he was a ten-year-old boy, it finally made sense.

Wasn’t that the age when even a falling leaf could make you sulk?

“What’s even more amusing is that he was first appointed City Lord five years ago.”

“…Five years old? That’s insane.”

What could a five-year-old possibly know? I could roughly guess why the public order in Shanxi Province had become such a mess. I also understood why Jin Mukyung had said that the Emperor, rather than the City Lord, was more incompetent.

This wasn’t some neighborhood corner store. They had put a child in a position that demanded ability and responsibility. There was no way things could run properly.

“How do you know all this?”

I asked because it was surprising that Jin Mukyung, who had been obsessed with martial arts and nothing else, was so well-informed about current affairs.

His answer was unexpected.

“Because I’ve met him before. More accurately, I was summoned.”

“Oh, really?”

“Three years ago.”

Well, if I was the rising super rookie of the moment, Jin Mukyung was already an established Peak master. It made sense that he would have been invited before me.

“What was he like?”

Jin Mukyung looked at me with a strange glint in his eyes.

Then, wearing an ominous expression that mixed laughter with irritation, he spoke.

“It was fucking awful.”

Chapter 130

Winter in the borderlands was harsh. A middle-aged man shivered violently as the knife-sharp wind cut through his collar.

“Ugh, it’s cold as hell.”

The man, Seokchil, was a porter for the Seongun Escort Bureau in southern Shanxi Province.

He had spent more than a day and a half hauling a cart loaded with over a hundred geun[753] of cargo, soaking his entire body in sweat. Whenever he took a brief rest, as he was now, he had to fight against the brutal cold.

“Hyung,[754] leave the cart and hurry over. Come warm yourself by the fire before you freeze to death.”

A fellow porter, already crouched in front of the campfire, called out. Seokchil answered gruffly as he walked over.

“Brat, I have five mouths to feed. I’ve got a long way to go before I can die.”

“True. You can’t die with a fox of a wife and rabbit-like children waiting for you.”

“What fox? She’s a bear. A bear.”

“Were those your last words? If your wife hears you, she’ll wring your neck.”

“You can curse the king behind his back. Didn’t you know?”

Seokchil moved closer to the campfire.

They used horse manure for firewood, so a foul smell spread in every direction. But after nearly twenty years as a porter, Seokchil was as used to it as he was to the smell of cooking rice.

“Ah, now I feel alive again.”

“But Hyung,[755] aren’t you being a little stingy?”

“Huh? What nonsense are you talking about now?”

His fellow porter grinned and jerked his chin toward something.

“You should bring the rookie over, too. Where’s the sense in rushing over here to save yourself alone?”

Seokchil, who had been warming his frozen hands, turned his head. At the end of his gaze sat a young man on a snow-covered rock, staring blankly into space.

That kid’s doing it again.

The young man was a new porter they had picked up in Henan. According to Escort Chief Song, who was in charge of this escort run, the young man seemed capable enough to earn his keep, so they had taken him on.

Well, we’re always short on people.

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[753] A Korean *geun* is 600 g, or about 1.32 lb. A hundred geun is 60 kg, or about 132 lb.

[754] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or older man.

[755] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or older man.

The problem was that no one could tell what the young man was thinking. He often sat there in a daze, just as he was doing now.

As Seokchil clicked his tongue, his fellow porter asked,

“Why? Is he a little strange?”

“He does his work well. He’s surprisingly strong for someone who doesn’t look like much.”

“Then what’s the problem?”

“What do you mean, what’s the problem? It’s frustrating to see a young fellow sitting around like that day after day. Back when I was his age…”

“You want to say you dreamed of making your mark on the world and worked hard every day?”

“Of course. A man should know how to set a grand goal and move toward it.”

“I assume that grand goal wasn’t becoming the greatest porter under heaven.”

“You little—”

At Seokchil’s furious reaction, his fellow porter quickly changed the subject.

“By the way, what’s that fellow’s name?”

“Cheongpung.”

“Now that’s a fine name. Suits him, too.”

“That’s true.”

Seokchil secretly disliked the young man, Cheongpung, but he had to agree completely.

Something about the young man’s open, pleasant features and clear eyes put people strangely at ease and soothed their anger.

“Hey, rookie!”

At his fellow porter’s shout, Cheongpung turned his head.

“Me?”

“Who else would I be talking to? Come over here and warm yourself by the fire. If you keep sitting there, your butt will get ripped right off.”

“An experience like that wouldn’t be bad.”

“An experience? What experience?”

“The experience of having my butt ripped off. I’ve never had that happen before.”

His fellow porter was silent for a moment before whispering to Seokchil,

“What kind of guy is he?”

“I don’t know. The kid’s a little strange. Maybe he ate something bad.”

Cheongpung tilted his head.

“I ate two dumplings this morning.”

“…Sharp ears, huh? Fine, just come sit down.”

“Should I?”

Cheongpung trudged over and sat down in front of the fire. The usual questions immediately began flying at him.

“Where are you from?”

“Henan.”

“So you’re from Henan.”

“I was in Hubei a month ago.”

“Hmm. Hubei’s nice, too.”

“Before that…”

The porter turned to Seokchil.

“This guy’s unbelievable.”

“Right? Talking to him makes me feel like I’m going strange, too.”

“How have you put up with him beside you for over a month?”

“That’s why I stopped talking to him lately. Has it been about three days since our last conversation?”

Cheongpung answered with a serious expression.

“Four days and three shichen.[756]”

“…”

“…”

The two men barely suppressed the urge to smack him over the head.

“So where are you from?”

“I lived in the mountains.”

“That’s not what I meant… No, never mind. Thank you for answering that, at least.”

“You’re welcome.”

Strangely, Cheongpung’s bright smile made their anger subside.

His unpredictable, bizarre remarks were paired with an innocent smile like a child’s. Their curiosity about this strange young man, unlike anyone they had ever seen, continued to grow.

“But you said you lived in the mountains?”

“Just like it sounds. I grew crops and gathered medicinal herbs there from the time I was young. I did all sorts of other things, too.”

The two men jumped to the conclusion that Cheongpung was from a slash-and-burn farming community.

Most slash-and-burn farmers went into the mountains to escape the cruelty of vicious landlords or to avoid the authorities after committing one crime or another.

“You must have had a hard life.”

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[756] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen are about six hours.

“But I had fun.”

“Oh, really?”

Could life as a slash-and-burn farmer really be fun? The thought briefly crossed Seokchil’s mind, but he saw no reason to ask.

“Then what made you come down from the mountain?”

“Life there got boring. I wanted to see the world, and there were people I wanted to meet.”

“So that’s why you came to Henan.”

“Yes. It turned out to be a wasted trip, but… things aren’t bad now, either. This escort work is pretty interesting, too.”

“You find escort work interesting?”

Cheongpung answered with a broad smile.

“Watching people is interesting. Looking at the land and the sky is interesting, too. Thinking is fun.”

To Seokchil, who had spent so many years as a porter, they were all sights he was sick to death of.

People worn down by exhaustion and worries about making a living. Damp earth and knife-sharp winds blowing like mad. The only thought filling his head was how much he would be paid for this escort run.

Well, he’s still young. That’s why he can say things like that.

Besides, he had lived in the mountains all his life and came from a slash-and-burn farming community. His attitude was understandable.

Wouldn’t he learn about the harsh realities of life soon enough and gradually become just like Seokchil as he grew older?

I used to be like that, too.

Seokchil looked at Cheongpung with a mixture of envy and pity before opening his mouth.

“Just listen to this as nonsense.”

He knew he was meddling where he wasn’t wanted, but he wanted to tell this innocent young man about the realities of life.

Wasn’t his life too promising to start as a porter and grow old and die as one?

“Anything seems worthwhile for a while. But after ten or twenty years, you stop seeing much of a future ahead of you. No matter how hard a porter works or how talented he is, he’s still a porter. You should learn even Third Rate martial arts at a local martial arts academy and start working as an escort. You’d be much better off.”

Cheongpung blinked.

“Oh, really?”

“Not ‘oh, really?‘ I’m telling you to do it. You’re a little old to start learning martial arts, but who knows? Maybe you have exceptional martial talent and could become a successful First Rate master.”

“A First Rate master…”

His fellow porter, who had been listening quietly, clicked his tongue.

“Isn’t that giving him too much false hope? A First Rate master isn’t some dog’s name.”

“I’m speaking hypothetically. What kind of sense does it make for someone his age to be satisfied with being a porter?”

“Well, you’re right about that. If I were ten years younger, I wouldn’t be doing this either.”

“See?”

Seokchil patted Cheongpung on the shoulder.

“You heard him, right? Save carefully for a year or two and enroll in a martial arts academy. It’ll be much better for you. Until then, I’ll teach you everything I know.”

Cheongpung tilted his head.

“A year or two?”

“What? Is that too long? You don’t know how the world works, so I suppose you don’t realize how expensive martial arts academy fees are. Even with the lowest estimate, it’ll take at least a year…”

“No, because I’m going to quit before then.”

“You’re quitting? When?”

“Now.”

“Huh?”

“What?”

Cheongpung smiled brightly.

“I don’t know the way to Shanxi Province. There happened to be an escort run heading to Shanxi, so I asked them to let me tag along.”

“…And?”

“We’ll reach Taiyuan after one more day, so I was planning to part ways around then.”

Seokchil and the other porter exchanged baffled looks.

“What the hell? Didn’t Escort Chief Song say he signed a one-year contract?”

“That’s what I heard, too. That’s why they assigned him to you, the most experienced porter, so he could learn from you.”

With a confused expression, Seokchil asked Cheongpung,

“When you joined us in Henan, you signed something, didn’t you?”

“Oh, yes.”

“If you have it, show it to me.”

Cheongpung pulled a yellowish bamboo slip from inside his clothes and showed it to them.

It was a contract stating that he would work as a porter for the Seongun Escort Bureau for one year and pay a penalty if he left before then.

“You can read, right?”

“I finished the Four Books and Three Classics when I was four.[757]”

“Don’t say stupid things like that. Read this part. Yes, that section. Read it aloud, and make sure I can hear you.”

Cheongpung read the section Seokchil indicated in a crisp voice.

“Once signed, this contract cannot be revoked. In the event of unauthorized departure, the signer shall pay a penalty of fifty silver nyang[758] or provide compensation of equivalent value.”

“You know how much fifty silver nyang[759] is, right? Do you know what ‘compensation of equivalent value’ means?”

Cheongpung thought deeply for a moment, then slapped his forehead.

“Does it mean I’d have to work it off?”

“That’s right, you idiot. Did you think the Escort Bureau was full of nothing but kindhearted saints?”

Seokchil’s blood pressure shot up, making the back of his neck throb. He wanted to crack open the top of the kid’s skull and see what was inside.

How can someone like this even exist? Is it because he only ever lived in the mountains?

The dangers of transporting goods across the land were beyond imagination. Mounted bandits, river bandits, mountain bandits, every kind of bandit gang imaginable, not to mention interference from competing Escort Bureaus.

Even if they overcame every one of those obstacles, a single natural disaster could doom an escort run.

An Escort Bureau was every bit as thorough and hard-edged as most Murim sects, if not more so.

And this kid signed the contract, then says what? “I’m leaving around here”?

The young fool in front of him knew far too little about the world.

Seokchil spoke, determined to keep the boy from throwing his life away.

“I’m telling you this just in case, so give up any thoughts of running away. Work for a year and think of it as earning money. Understand?”

“A year is too long. I think I can work through tomorrow, though.”

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[757] The Four Books and Three Classics are foundational Confucian texts.

[758] A *nyang* is a historical unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won. Fifty silver nyang is the contract’s stated penalty.

[759] A *nyang* is a historical unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won. Fifty silver nyang is the contract’s stated penalty.

"You little bastard!"

"Hyung,[760] Hyung,[761] calm down! If Escort Chief Song happens to see this, we'll all be in trouble."

"Let go! I said let go!"

It was just then, as Seokchil was about to snap.

"Uh, wouldn't this be enough to cover the penalty?"

Clink.

The two men's eyes widened at what Cheongpung held out.

The object was shaped like a horse's hoof and gleamed with a silver light whiter than the snow.

"S-silver yuanbao?[762]"

"And there are two of them!"

Two silver yuanbao,[763] each worth fifty silver nyang.[764]

A hundred silver nyang[765] was an enormous sum that an ordinary porter would struggle to earn even after working himself to the bone for ten years.

And yet such a fortune had come from the clothes of a young man from a slash-and-burn farming community.

"H-how…?"

"I was given some traveling money when I left home."

Both men's mouths fell open at Cheongpung's innocent reply.

What kind of family gave their son a hundred silver nyang[766] as traveling money? And judging from the money pouch hanging limp like a bull's testicles, this didn't seem to be all he had.

"At least it looks like this should cover the penalty…"

The two men nodded frantically.

"It can. Of course it can."

"Why did you suddenly start speaking formally?"

"It's just more comfortable this way."

"Exactly. It's the most comfortable thing in the world."

"Oh. If that's what you prefer."

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[760] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or older man.

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[762] A *yuanbao* is an ingot of precious metal used as currency. Each of these silver ingots is worth fifty silver nyang.

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[765] A hundred silver nyang is twice the contract's stated penalty.

[766] A hundred silver nyang is twice the contract's stated penalty.

Cheongpung looked at the two men as if they were strange and handed over the two silver yuanbao.[767]

“I’ll be going, then. Please tell them this is the penalty.”

“A-are you giving us both?”

“It’s too much…”

“If there’s anything left over, you two can split it. I don’t really know how to spend money. Buy yourselves some warm clothes. Something with expensive fur.”

“…!”

As Cheongpung slung a bundle over his shoulder and prepared to leave, Seokchil hurriedly called after him.

“C-could I ask your name?”

“Cheongpung. Until half a month ago, I was from Henan. Last month, I lived in Hubei, and before that, I was in Shaanxi.”

With that, Cheongpung strode off toward Taiyuan.

The sky was blue, and early shoots were already sprouting from the damp earth.

“Maybe spring will come a little early this year.”

He smiled brightly as he thought about it. He hoped the plum blossoms would bloom in profusion again this spring.

Then, without warning, he thought of Lotus Peak on Huashan, from which he had secretly run away not long ago.

[767] A *yuanbao* is an ingot of precious metal used as currency. Each of these silver ingots is worth fifty silver nyang.

Chapter 131

"Fresh-killed pork, twenty coins per geun[768]! Cheap, cheap!"

"Oh my, that ring looks perfect on you. It's normally one silver nyang, but since your fingers are so pretty, I'll let you have it for half a nyang. What do you say?"

"As for this pill, just one will clear your mind and fill you with strength…"

The streets were packed with endless rows of stalls and the booming cries of merchants.

When I saw the crowded streets of Taiyuan, I clicked my tongue in amazement.

There are a hell of a lot of people.

There was quite a variety among them, too. There were not only street vendors, but also quack medicine sellers, people dressed in smooth silk, and beggars whose poverty practically poured off them.

Martial artists with swords at their waists were also a common sight, but no one paid them any particular attention. Everyone simply went about their business.

So this is the capital of Shanxi Province.

Shanxi Province had dozens of counties and towns, but Taiyuan held a special place among them.

Thanks to its many advantages, it had once served as the capital of a dynasty in the distant past.

That dynasty had fallen long ago, of course, but Taiyuan had continued to develop afterward…

Or so Hyuk Mujin had told me.

That must be why the Jin Family of Taiyuan has managed to survive for three hundred years.

Abundant supplies and manpower. And economic power.

Come to think of it, even after one worthless son raided the family coffers and blew it all at a pleasure house, they still had enough left to wage war against the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

If they had been the Jin Family of Mount Heng instead of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, they would have gone bankrupt and ended up on the streets long ago.

You can't pass through Taiyuan without setting foot on the Jin Family of Taiyuan's land.

As I recalled the saying, Hyuk Mujin asked, "What are you thinking about so hard?"

"Just that land speculation really pays off."

"What?"

[768] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g, or about 1.32 lb.

"It's nothing. You…"

"Don't need to know?"

"You catch on fast."

"I'm getting tired of hearing that."

"Yeah, I'm getting tired of you, too."

"Then why did you bring me?"

"Let's get the facts straight. I didn't bring you. Eldest Brother assigned you to me."

Jin Wikyung had sent me ahead to prepare for tomorrow's luncheon with Shanxi's City Lord. The City Lord was a temperamental child, so Wikyung probably wanted us to accommodate him as much as possible and avoid any trouble.

In any case, that was why Hyuk Mujin was traveling with me. As a native of Taiyuan, he was an ideal attendant in many ways.

"Come to think of it, isn't this your hometown?"

"My hometown… Yes, it is."

Hyuk Mujin stared at the streets with a complicated look in his eyes.

"It's only been five years, but so much has changed."

"You must've stopped by a few times in between."

"No. I haven't been back once."

His unexpected answer caught me by surprise.

"Not even once in five years?"

"I started learning martial arts rather late. If I wanted to catch up with everyone else, I had no choice but to work ten or twenty times harder."

"Hmm."

"I never thought I'd come back like this."

It was the first time in a long while—no, almost the first time ever—that I had seen him look so serious.

Come to think of it, Hyuk Mujin might fool around constantly, but he was still a capable First Rate master. He only seemed unimpressive because he was surrounded by monsters. His realm was by no means low.

He could never have reached it without working himself to the bone. And on top of that…

He seems to have some talent, too.

His rapidly rising Level was proof enough.

At this rate, is he going to become a Peak master before I know it?

Despite my newly appreciative gaze, Hyuk Mujin was too absorbed in the emotions of returning to his hometown after so long.

“Ah, that auntie is still here.”

His voice was happy, yet wistful.

He pointed to a gray-streaked middle-aged woman selling all kinds of snacks from a small stall.

“Do you like candied hawthorn skewers[769]?”

Normally, I would have told him to stop talking nonsense and keep moving, but the mood was unusual. I answered as kindly as I could.

“I’ve never had one in my life.”

“When I was little, I wanted them so badly. Whenever I crouched in front of her stall and sucked on my fingers, that auntie would give me one or two.”

Hyuk Mujin continued with a bitter smile.

“You have no idea how jealous I was of the other children. They’d come holding their parents’ hands, buy candied hawthorn[770] and sweets, and wander around the market… I can still picture it.”

What was I supposed to do with this mood?

I had figured there must be a story behind him, but I hadn’t expected it to take this turn.

I should’ve known when he said he hadn’t come back in five years.

There were an unusually large number of orphans in the Murim. Even looking around us, it was easy to find children wandering through the market in filthy rags.

He must have been in a similar situation.

With no family, he had no reason to return. Coming back would only stir up painful memories of lingering outside the stall as a child, longing for candied hawthorn[771].

Maybe that was why he had tried to forget his pain through training.

For him, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been home, and his companions had been his family.

And without knowing any of that… I’ve been treating him far too harshly.

Damn it. The tip of my nose was starting to sting for no reason.

Hyuk Mujin immediately noticed the change in me.

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[769] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

[770] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

[771] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

"What's wrong?"

"No, it's nothing. Maybe the fine dust is especially bad today. My nose feels itchy."

"Fine dust?"

"Never mind that. Why don't we get a candied hawthorn skewer[772] each?"

"Wouldn't it be better to find an inn first? If we don't get a room before the sun goes down, there may not be any left."

"Hey, how long does it take to eat one of those? They're not even that expensive. We were given plenty of travel expenses, weren't we?"

"That's true."

"Let's eat whatever we want and have all the fun we can before we leave. You can pay that auntie back for the treats she gave you by giving her plenty of business."

"I'm not sure we should spend money meant for necessities like this…"

"Spend it. Spend all of it. If anyone complains later, bring them to me."

"What if the Second Young Master complains?"

"…Bring me anyone except him."

Hyuk Mujin let out a short laugh before speaking in a much brighter voice.

"Then shall we get a skewer each?"

"Sure. I've been looking at them for a while, and they're making my mouth water."

I said it entirely for Hyuk Mujin's benefit. I was almost thirty. Why would fruit candy make my mouth water?

As long as it cheers him up.

That guy had suffered plenty while following me around. He was constantly berated and beaten, and every time we took on a Quest, we ended up meeting nothing but monsters. He had come close to dying more than once.

My first meeting with Hyuk Mujin had certainly been an ill-fated one, but that was no longer true.

"Hey, Mujin."

Hyuk Mujin, who had just started walking toward the stall, stopped short.

"Yes? What is it?"

"Well…"

The words *I'm counting on you from here on out* hovered on the tip of my tongue. Damn it. That was much too sappy for two grown men to say to each other.

After agonizing over it, I blurted out something completely different.

"Let's get two each. The big ones."

"Oh. Yes."

[772] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

Too embarrassed to look at him, I gazed off at a distant mountain. Hyuk Mujin's conversation with the middle-aged woman drifted to my ears.

"Oh my! Aren't you Mujin? Hyuk Mujin, right?"

"It's been a long time, Auntie."

"My goodness, it is you. It is! I almost didn't recognize you, child."

"You haven't changed at all, Auntie."

"Ho-ho-ho. That's kind of you to say. Have you been well, Mujin? I heard you became a martial artist."

"Yes. I belong to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I'll be promoted to Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion soon."

"T-the Jin Family of Taiyuan? Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion? My goodness, my goodness…"

Whether he would actually be promoted remained to be seen, but their conversation brought a pleased smile to my face.

This sounds like a radio call-in story.

A kindhearted auntie who used to give candied hawthorn[773] to an orphan boy who lingered around her stall. After a childhood of hardship and years of grueling effort, the boy finally found success and returned as a strapping young man.

It was a story I had heard somewhere before, but that didn't make it any less moving.

"Ahem. What is this? Did something get in my eye?"

Was it yellow dust[774] or fine dust? They couldn't have built any factories yet, so it must have been yellow dust[775].

That was when the rims of my eyes reddened slightly despite myself.

"So, have you gone to see your parents?"

"Not yet. I was thinking of stopping by today or tomorrow."

"Go see them soon. Didn't your family move?"

"Moved? Where?"

"To a large estate along the main road over there. They even released koi into the pond and raised them."

"Oh, really?"

…?

Parents? Moving? A huge estate with koi?

Wait. Something wasn't right.

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[773] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

[774] Yellow dust is windborne dust from arid regions of East Asia that can affect air quality in Korea.

[775] Yellow dust is windborne dust from arid regions of East Asia that can affect air quality in Korea.

I stared dumbfoundedly at Hyuk Mujin as he returned carrying the candied hawthorn skewers[776].

“What was that about?”

“Huh? About what?”

“Your parents are alive?”

Hyuk Mujin stared at me as though I were insane.

“Why are you killing off my perfectly healthy parents?”

“No, that’s not what I meant… Then what was all that stuff you said earlier?”

“What stuff?”

“The candied hawthorn[777]. You said you couldn’t have any and spent every day sucking on your fingers.”

“I couldn’t have any. My parents wouldn’t let me eat it because they said it would rot my teeth. Every merchant around here knew how overbearing my parents were, so they made a point of refusing to sell any to me. That lady was the only one who secretly slipped me some.”

…

“And what about being jealous of the children holding their parents’ hands?”

“My family’s business was so successful that they never had any free time. I played by myself.”

“Th-then you had family in Taiyuan, but you didn’t come back once in five years?”

“I left home. I didn’t want to inherit the family business, so I left a single letter behind and ran away. The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion in our family is my father’s childhood best friend, so he probably knew everything about how I was doing.”

…

“For about two years, they gave me hell over it. Then my youngest sibling was suddenly born, so I no longer needed to inherit the family business. After that, they stopped saying much.”

Hyuk Mujin craned his neck and looked around, then raised a hand and pointed.

“Ah, there it is. See it? That building belongs to my parents… It got even bigger while I was away.”

I followed Hyuk Mujin’s finger and turned my head.

A huge, towering five-story pavilion and a signboard bearing enormous characters came into view.

Hyuk Family Textile Shop

Hyuk Mujin smiled proudly.

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[776] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

[777] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

“It’s the largest textile shop in Taiyuan. We have branches in Henan and Hebei, too.”

This bastard was born with a silver spoon, too…

You had to be pretty damn wealthy to open chain stores in a place this rough.

What the hell have I been doing?

A young boy who used to suck on his fingers because he wanted to eat candied hawthorn[778] so badly?

The truth was that his successful business-owner parents had forbidden him from eating it because they were worried about his teeth.

What the fuck is this?

As I stood there with my mouth hanging open, Hyuk Mujin held out one of the candied hawthorn skewers[779].

“Here, have one. I specially chose the biggest and shiniest one. The ones that lady sells are the best in this area.”

“You son of a…”

I swallowed the curse that had surged up to my throat and bit down on the candied hawthorn[780] with a loud crunch.

“Let’s hurry up and find a room.”

“Already? We’ve only spent a few iron coins…”

“Hey! Is it your money? Those are travel expenses we were given to spend when necessary. Expenses!”

“Didn’t you just say we should spend it all and have fun?”

“We’ve had enough fun. You said the rooms would fill up after sunset. If we get a bad night’s sleep and end up late to tomorrow’s luncheon, are you going to take responsibility?”

…

Honghwa Inn.

As its signboard suggested, this was one of the establishments under the Lower District Sect’s influence.

Honghwaru at night. Honghwa Inn for lodging.

Whoever had come up with that arrangement was clearly determined to wring every last coin out of the drunks.

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[778] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

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[780] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

"Let's go in."

I was about to lead Hyuk Mujin, whose lower lip had been jutting out for some time, toward the inn's entrance when someone spoke.

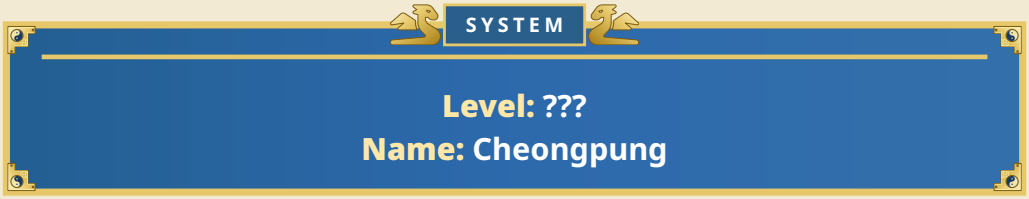
"Excuse me. I'm sorry to bother you."

The voice strangely tugged at my nerves. Its owner was a young man with an affable expression and a dreamy, hazy voice as innocent as a child's.

This feeling…

The moment I turned around and met his clear eyes, my breath caught despite myself.

This was an aura different from Jin Mukyung's.



Another Peak master had appeared.

Amid the tension, the young man named Cheongpung opened his lips.

"If you don't mind, may I eat just one candied hawthorn skewer[781]?"

…?

What the hell is this guy?

[781] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

Chapter 132

"If it wouldn't be too much trouble, may I have just one candied hawthorn skewer?[782]"

The unexpected comment caused my brain to freeze for a moment.

What the hell is he talking about?

It wasn't one of those *Do you know the Way?*[783] pitches. He was asking if he could have just one candied hawthorn skewer.

I hadn't planned for a Peak master I'd just met to beg for candied hawthorn in the most polite tone in the world.

Grrrrrrowl.

Now he was even tugging at my pity with his stomach clock. Without thinking, I held out the candied hawthorn skewer I was still holding.

"H-here."

"Thank you, Benefactor."

Talk about value for money. Ten seconds after meeting him, I had become a Peak master's Benefactor.

Hyuk Mujin and I stared blankly at Cheongpung as he ferociously bit and sucked on a sugary snack meant for children.

"Captain, do you know him?"

"No."

Cheongpung devoured the candied hawthorn skewer as though it had vanished in the blink of an eye. Apparently, it hadn't been enough, because he turned the eyes of a starving beast on Hyuk Mujin.

More precisely, on the two candied hawthorn skewers in Mujin's hands.

"…Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Give them to him."

Hyuk Mujin quickly hid his hands behind his back.

"No."

"No?"

"Yes. This is the first time I've eaten these in five years. I haven't even taken a bite yet."

"I see. Our Mujin wants to die about fifty years ahead of schedule."

"…"

With a deep sigh, he held out the skewers. Cheongpung's eyes flashed.

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[782] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional Chinese snack made by coating skewered fruit in hardened sugar.

[783] "Do you know the Way?" evokes an opening used by street proselytizers in South Korea.

"Thank you, Benefactor!"

The next moment, there was a sharp *whoosh*, and the skewers were in Cheongpung's hands.

"Gah!"

That was incredible speed. Hyuk Mujin sucked in a startled breath and whispered to me in a trembling voice.

"H-he's no ordinary beggar, is he?"

What kind of face would Mujin make if he learned that the filthy young man in front of us was a Peak master?

I studied Cheongpung as he inhaled the candied hawthorn with single-minded focus.

He looks far too young to be a Peak master.

I had heard a few rumors by now. I also knew that even famous, powerful sects with every kind of genius training and support only produced a Peak master once in a blue moon.

That was why Jin Mukyung, who came from Shanxi Province—a remote backwater even by the standards of the Central Plains—had become so famous.

He had reached the Peak realm ten or twenty years ahead of everyone else.

But…

The young man in front of me looked barely my age, yet he was a Peak master whose Level I couldn't even determine through Qi Sense.

I had never heard of a Peak master this young in Shanxi Province.

Where the hell did this guy come from?

As if on cue, Cheongpung raised his head. He had eaten so hurriedly that sticky sugar covered the corners of his mouth.

"Whew. That was delicious."

"You must've been a little… very hungry."

"Yes. I haven't eaten all day."

"Oh dear. How did that happen?"

"I lost my travel money. Still, it was an interesting experience."

"…"

Could starving all day because you had no money really count as an interesting experience?

I had sensed it from the moment we met, but this guy definitely had a peculiar way of thinking.

Cheongpung smiled brightly and gave us a respectful fist-and-palm salute.

"Ah, I'm late introducing myself. Cheongpung offers his greetings to his Benefactors."

"My name is Jin Taekyung."

"And I'm this man's right arm and heart, Hyuk Mujin."

I completely ignored Hyuk Mujin's nonsense and kept my eyes on Cheongpung.

I might not look it, but I was fairly famous in Shanxi Province.

Until a few months ago, I had been famous for all the wrong reasons. Now, for the exact opposite reason, there wasn't a soul in Shanxi Province who didn't know my name.

I wonder if he'll recognize me.

Just as I was secretly getting my hopes up, Cheongpung's face went stiff.

"Excuse me, are you perhaps…"

"Yes, that's right. I'm the very—"

"Would it be all right if I imposed on you a little longer?"

"What?"

"I've been hungry for quite a long time."

Right on cue, a thunderous sound came from Cheongpung's stomach.

Grrrrrrowl.

"…Then why don't we have a meal together?"

"Thank you, Benefactor!"

I couldn't tell whether I was his Benefactor or just a sucker.

Honghwa Inn was packed with people who had come for an early dinner.

A quick-footed waiter led us to one of the few remaining empty tables.

"What'll it be?"

I handed Cheongpung the wooden Murim-style menu.

"Order whatever you want."

"Oh, no, I couldn't. I'm not some ungrateful beast who doesn't know how to repay a kindness. How could I…"

"It's fine. Order whatever you want."

"Then I'll have everything on here."

"…"

What an ungrateful beast.

The appearance of a colossal sucker kept the kitchen busy. Before long, the dishes we had ordered began pouring out without pause.

"Garlic Pork is here. This dish is made by slicing boiled pork thin and…"

"Oh."

"Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork is here. It's pork served with bamboo shoots, wood ear mushrooms, and…"

"Ohhh."

“Beijing Sauce Shredded Pork.”

“Ohhhh!”

“Beggar’s Chicken.”

“Ohhhhh!”

Unlike the waiter, whose explanations had grown shorter and shorter, Cheongpung’s reactions were becoming more and more elaborate.

Dish after dish continued filling the table. Just as there was barely any room left, the waiter slid out another plate with the expression of a man who had reached enlightenment.

“Maegu.”

“Maegu?”

I’d heard of Megumi from the island country next door, but Maegu was a new one to me. Catching my look, the waiter answered as if explaining it was a chore.

“Maechae Guyuk.”[784]

“…”

Now he was even abbreviating dish names.

While I stared at him in disbelief, Cheongpung rapidly emptied the plates.

“Nom, nom.”

“Slow down. Eat slowly.”

“Ah hih he ho. Ha hu i heup hi ha.”

“Don’t answer. Just keep eating.”

“Khanks hah!”

Hyuk Mujin whispered with a thoroughly disgusted expression.

“Isn’t he really a beggar?”

“Didn’t you see him snatch the candied hawthorn earlier? No way.”

Chomp, chomp.

“…Probably not.”

“What if he’s a master of the Beggars’ Sect?”

“The Beggars’ Sect, huh?”

I had seen it countless times in martial arts novels. It also existed openly in the actual Murim as one of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

I had yet to meet one of its members, but any of the beggars loitering near the inn’s entrance could be a Beggars’ Sect disciple.

“Should I take a quick look and see if he has any knots?”

The masters of the Beggars’ Sect supposedly distinguished their status by the knots around their waists.

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[784] *Maechae Guyuk* is pork belly with preserved mustard greens. The waiter shortens its Korean name to *Maegu*, which sounds like the beginning of the Japanese name Megumi.

I shook my head.

No. He isn't with the Beggars' Sect.

If he were, he would have reacted somehow when he heard my name. We belonged to the same orthodox faction, so he had no reason to pretend he didn't recognize me.

Then what sect is he from?

There was no way a Peak master this young had simply dropped out of the sky.

He had to be from a famous sect at the very least… The more I thought about it, the more curious I became about this mysterious young man.

"Burp. That was delicious."

Cheongpung finally finished eating. After patting his tadpole-like belly, he looked at Hyuk Mujin and me, then stopped short.

"It was my first time trying any of these dishes, so I made a spectacle of myself in front of my Benefactors. I hope I didn't overdo it…"

You already overdid it, you idiot.

Still, it was good that he had at least a little self-awareness.

"It's fine. I do that sometimes, too."

"We have something in common. Ha-ha."

I laughed along with Cheongpung and opened my mouth. It was about time I started a background check on this sucker.

"You said it was your first time trying all of this. I suppose you don't usually eat rich food."

Cheongpung shook his head gloomily.

"It's not that I don't. I couldn't. If I'd known food this delicious existed, I would have come down from the mountain sooner."

"Oh, so you lived in the mountains. That must've been difficult."

"Life in the mountains? It was fun. The scenery was beautiful, and there was plenty to eat all over the place. My grandfather has lived alone in the mountains his entire life, too."

"Your grandfather?"

"Yes. But, um…"

"Go ahead."

"May I order some alcohol? I've never tried it before."

"…Order as much as you like."

This kid had a lot of things he'd never tried.

At least he still had a sliver of conscience left. He ordered the cheapest bottle of fire liquor.

A short while later, Cheongpung downed the fire liquor without hesitation and muttered, his face slightly flushed.

“Ahh, so this is what it means to get drunk. But what were we talking about?”

“Your grandfather living alone in the mountains his entire life.”

“Oh, right. Anyway, I’ve lived with my grandfather since I was little. I was five when we started living together, so it’s already been fifteen years.”

“Really? That’s a long time.”

I did my best not to show my surprise.

A Peak master at barely twenty.

That meant he was a genius at least comparable to Jin Mukyung, if not greater. The more I talked with him, the more curious I became about his identity.

“Where is it? If it’s such a nice place to live, maybe I could visit sometime.”

Cheongpung hesitated just as he was about to say something.

“Um, I don’t think I can tell you that.”

“Come on. You can’t even tell me that much?”

“Because my grandfather hates it so much… He already moves to a different place once or twice a year because of that.”

“He moves?”

“Yes. Strange people keep coming to see him.”

Strange people? Obnoxious hikers?

Well, I suppose it would be annoying for someone living in the mountains.

He continued with a nostalgic look in his eyes.

“When I was ten, dozens of people suddenly came rushing over and started causing trouble. I remember my grandfather shouting at them to get lost before he set the mountain on fire.”

“Oh, so that’s why he keeps moving?”

“Yes. Fortunately, the mountains are huge, so he’s managed to avoid them for ten years.”

“…”

Ten years? His grandfather was quite a man.

Hyuk Mujin, who had been listening to Cheongpung’s story with great interest, asked, “Then why did you come down from the mountain, Young Master?”

Cheongpung, who had been sucking on the mouth of the liquor bottle regretfully, answered,

“Because of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

“The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes? What’s that supposed to be?”

At my question, Hyuk Mujin looked at me as though I were the strangest person he had ever seen.

“Why don’t you know about the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, Captain?”

“I’m allowed not to know, damn it.”

“Huh? Last year, you got plastered at a pleasure house and made a complete fool of yourself bragging that you were going to become one of them.”

“That wasn’t me… Never mind. What are the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?”

“Are you seriously asking because you don’t know?”

“Can’t I just not know?”

“Of course you can’t. The Second Young Master is one of them, after all.”

Wait, really?

As I blinked at him, Hyuk Mujin launched into an impassioned explanation.

“They’re the greatest young prodigies of the orthodox Murim! The dragons and phoenixes who will lead the Murim of the future! How can you not know about the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?”

“Hey, hey. Keep your voice down. People are staring.”

I wasn’t exaggerating. Hyuk Mujin’s booming voice had drawn glances from the other customers.

“Who cares if they stare? This is too much even for you, Captain! Are you making fun of me?”

“I don’t know about making fun of people, but I’m good at hitting them.”

“I think I got too worked up. I’m sorry.”

Hyuk Mujin regained his composure in an instant. I turned away from him and gave Cheongpung a friendly smile.

“Please continue.”

“It’s nothing important. I just had a childish thought for a moment.”

Cheongpung gazed at me through slightly unfocused eyes. Apparently, he had no intention of using his internal energy to dispel the drunkenness, because he still looked a little tipsy.

“Who would be stronger, me or them? I wanted to find the answer to that question.”

In the end, it came down to a martial artist’s competitive pride.

The desire to venture into a new world. The desire to defeat the strong and prove his martial arts. I could tell those feelings had led him down the mountain.

He seems to have the skill to justify thinking that way, too.

Jin Mukyung had supposedly reached the Peak realm at barely twenty, causing an uproar throughout the Central Plains. Now he was counted among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, the greatest young prodigies of the orthodox faction.

The Cheongpung in front of me possessed martial talent at least comparable to Jin Mukyung’s.

He has every right to think so.

I was nodding inwardly when—

“Puhahaha!”

“Pfft, hahahaha. Ah, holding back my laughter was torture.”

I raised my head toward the source of the sound.

On the second floor, five men and women dressed in silk were looking down at us, their faces full of mockery.

Chapter 133

Woo Jintae raised his golden wine cup. Five men and women, including him, sat around a table laden with every manner of delicacy and fine liquor.

“Now, to the boundless prosperity of the Five Gates of Shanxi!”

“To prosperity!”

“To prosperity!”

After the wine made its way around once, smiles spread across all five faces.

“As expected of Honghwa Inn. I don’t know who the chef is, but the food is incredible.”

“Right? It practically melts the moment it touches your tongue.”

Woo Jintae let out a hearty laugh.

“Ha-ha! Loosen your belts and eat to your hearts’ content. I’m paying for everything again today.”

“Wow, as expected of you, hyung[785]! At this rate, aren’t you going to pull up one of the foundation pillars of the Seongun Escort Bureau?”

“Oh my, can you afford all this?”

Woo Jintae chuckled as he looked at the two men and two women before him.

They were the scions of the Five Gates of Shanxi, the leading sects in an alliance of twenty small and medium-sized sects. Even so, they had to defer to him.

“Come now, I’m Woo Jintae. Woo Jintae of the Seongun Escort Bureau! I could buy this entire inn and it wouldn’t be a problem, so don’t worry and eat as much as you like.”

There was a touch of boasting in his words, but they weren’t entirely untrue.

The Seongun Escort Bureau dominated the area around Three Questions Gorge and raked in an enormous fortune each year from transportation, security, and various other businesses.

And Woo Jintae was its heir.

Money really is the best.

The Five Gates of Shanxi were still just a bunch of scions from similarly modest sects. With the Seongun Escort Bureau’s wealth behind him, nothing stood in his way.

“Thanks to everyone here, our Seongun Escort Bureau has risen another step. It’s only right that I treat you accordingly, wouldn’t you agree?”

Everyone hurriedly waved him off.

“Oh, how could that be thanks to us? It’s all because the Chief and you have worked tirelessly day and night for the Escort Bureau’s growth.”

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[785] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“That’s right. We could never accept such praise from Young Hero Woo.”

They said money could make even ghosts do your bidding. How much easier would it be with the living?

Worked tirelessly day and night, huh? Well, that isn’t entirely wrong.

The Seongun Escort Bureau was neither a prestigious martial family nor a proper Murim sect. It had managed to join the Five Gates of Shanxi because it had thrown money around.

The Sect Leaders, senior members, and scions of more than twenty small and medium-sized sects…

Woo Jintae had stuffed all of them with liquor and money day and night, and the results had been undeniable.

The Five Gates of Shanxi.

It was a position that could be called the representative of the alliance of small and medium-sized sects in the south.

For an ordinary Murim sect, it would have been nothing more than a hollow honorary position. But for the Seongun Escort Bureau, which generated profits through all kinds of businesses, it was like growing wings.

Woo Jintae bowed his head with a deliberately solemn expression.

“No. The Seongun Escort Bureau is where it is today because of all of you. Until just a few months ago, those vile old monsters had us living without being able to hold our heads up… Once again, thank you.”

“Those old monsters? You mean the traitors?”

“Ugh, don’t even mention them. If this hadn’t happened, all of us would have been helplessly used by them.”

Everyone gathered here was now a scion of the Five Gates of Shanxi, but that hadn’t been true just a few months ago.

The Samdo Sect, the Gunggui Sect, and three others had made up the former Five Gates of Shanxi. But at the Battle of Eight Spring Gorge, they had been exposed as the Head Elder’s lackeys and annihilated to the last sect.

“Now that I think about it, those bastards were especially wary of the Seongun Escort Bureau.”

“They were clearly afraid that their identities would be exposed by the keen insight of the Chief and Woo Jintae.”

Woo Jintae suppressed the laughter threatening to burst out.

The reason the former Five Gates of Shanxi had kept the Seongun Escort Bureau in check was simple.

They were worried about exactly this.

The Five Gates of Shanxi had been much stronger back then, and their bonds had been far tighter.

But not anymore. Everyone here had already gotten a taste of the Seongun Escort Bureau's money. From there, it was only a matter of time before he used that leverage to nibble away at their various business interests.

"Now, let's raise a toast to our friendship."

"To friendship!"

The lively drinking continued, and Woo Jintae occasionally handed out bribes under the guise of gifts.

"This is Shu brocade I brought in from Sichuan. I thought it would suit Young Lady Hwang, so I set some aside for you."

"Oh my! You mean the Shu brocade I know?"

"Yes. It's the finest grade, and perhaps that's why the color is so exceptionally beautiful. I told a servant to load it into the carriage beforehand, so please take it with you."

"My goodness, Young Hero Woo. Thank you so much."

"Is there any need to thank me? Just think of it as the feelings I have for you and put it away."

"Wh-what?"

"Ha-ha, that came out wrong. Pretend you didn't hear it."

At Woo Jintae's charming smile, the only daughter of a martial sect with more than a hundred affiliated martial artists blushed.

Once I make her indebted to me, there will be a day when I can put that debt to use.

"Hyung[786], now I'm hurt. How can you only look after the young ladies?"

This time, he winked at the scion of a martial family who had become close enough with him to call each other hyung[787] and little brother.

"As if I could forget you, Little Brother Hyuk. Just wait. I've prepared an absolutely incredible gift for you."

"Damn, as expected of you, hyung[788]."

"Ha-ha, Jintae, you haven't forgotten me, have you?"

"What a hurtful thing to say. I only planned to tell each of you separately because I chose a gift suited to each person."

It was easy. Expensive silk and jewelry for the women, and peerless beauties and wealth for the men.

Honghwaru, reputedly the finest pleasure house in Shanxi Province, happened to be nearby. It was perfect.

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[786] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[787] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[788] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Woo Jintae smiled as he watched everyone's delight.

"Now that everyone's had a chance to unwind, I was thinking we might end tonight's drinking here… What do you all think?"

They might have been disappointed before receiving their gifts, but things were different now.

The women nodded, eager to check the silk and jewelry loaded into the carriage, while the men's hearts pounded at the certainty that they would be moving to the pleasure house.

"Then let's have a few final cups before we leave. And don't forget tomorrow's luncheon."

Everyone chuckled at Woo Jintae's words.

"How could we forget that, no matter how drunk we get?"

"You really underestimate us, Jintae."

"I only mentioned it just in case. Ha-ha-ha."

A luncheon with the City Lord of Shanxi.

That was why the scions of the sects with some clout in Shanxi had gathered in one place. Woo Jintae emptied his wine cup and thought,

I'm looking forward to tomorrow.

The City Lord was a mere ten years old.

Woo Jintae was already a master at catering to people's whims, and he had finished making every possible preparation to win the City Lord over.

I hear he's quite a mischievous little fellow… He's a member of the imperial family, so I wonder what he'll be like.

Just as Woo Jintae was lost in thought, a booming shout erupted from downstairs.

"The greatest young prodigies of the Murim's orthodox faction! The dragons and phoenixes who will lead the Murim of the future! How can you say you don't know the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?"

"Hey, hey. Keep your voice down. People are staring."

At the words *Ten Dragons and Phoenixes*, five pairs of ears perked up.

Who were the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes? They were geniuses already writing the first page of their legends—the future of the Murim's orthodox faction.

They were the objects of every rising martial artist's admiration, and those gathered here were no exception.

"Who are they? Martial artists?"

The person seated closest to the railing craned his neck and looked down at the first floor.

"There are three of them. One's a young master, another looks somewhat like a martial artist… and the last looks like a beggar."

"What kind of combination is that?"

"Shh. Let's keep listening."

At Woo Jintae's urging, everyone fell silent and pricked up their ears again.

They had all trained in martial arts as befitted scions of martial families, so overhearing the conversation was not difficult.

"Please continue."

"It's nothing important. I just had a childish thought for a moment."

There was a brief silence. Then another statement followed.

"Who would be stronger, me or them? I wanted to find the answer to that question."

The young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi looked at one another.

"Did you all hear that?"

"Yes. Who said it?"

"That beggar I mentioned. You really do see all kinds of lunatics these days."

Woo Jintae shook his head.

"He's probably a martial artist, not a beggar."

"A martial artist…?"

"If he's talking about the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, that must be it. As for how he ended up looking like a beggar, well, I can guess without even seeing him."

A mocking laugh escaped Woo Jintae's lips.

"Isn't it obvious? He's the type who picks up a few Third Rate martial arts moves by chance, puts his faith in them, wanders aimlessly through the martial world, and winds up dead."

"Ah, now that you mention it, you're right. As expected of Young Hero Woo."

"The more I think about it, the funnier it gets. How did someone like that dare mention the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?"

The young prodigies snickered at one another, and their laughter gradually grew louder.

"That tells you all you need to know about the people who associate with a lunatic like him. Or maybe they'll slap him across the face, call him crazy, and walk out."

"What are the young master and the martial artist sitting with him doing?"

The young prodigy who glanced downstairs again answered while stifling his laughter.

"I don't know about the martial artist, but the young master is nodding to himself."

"Well, now."

"Really?"

"Wow, you should all see his expression. He genuinely seems to believe that beggar."

The young prodigies rose and approached the railing. Woo Jintae, unable to contain his curiosity, went with them.

Let's at least see what these fools look like.

The moment he saw the young master nodding with a serious expression, a loud laugh burst from his mouth.

"Puhahaha!"

At the same time, the other young prodigies began laughing loudly as well.

"Pfft, ha-ha-ha! I almost died trying to hold that in."

"Ha-ha-ha! They don't know the first thing about martial arts, yet they're talking about the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?"

How long did they laugh?

When they finally managed to stop, what they saw was one person staring quietly up at them.

"Finished laughing?"

At the 'young master's' words, the young prodigies froze.

They had all been raised precious and pampered. How long had it been since anyone had spoken down to them like that?

Woo Jintae's dry voice broke the sudden, icy silence.

"And if we have?"

The 'young master' smiled brightly.

"Get down here right now, you fucking sons of bitches. My neck hurts."

Hyuk Mujin asked with an expectant look in his eyes,

"Are you going to fight them?"

"Depends on what they do."

"Once you've called them fucking sons of bitches, isn't that asking for a fight?"

"That works, too. See all the spit those bastards sprayed on my face?"

"You're completely drenched."

Hyuk Mujin briskly wiped my face with his sleeve.

"What if they don't apologize?"

"They'd better."

"Look at their faces. They're never going to apologize."

"Then they'll get the shit beaten out of them."

"There are women among them, too…"

"I believe in gender equality."

"What?"

"I beat everyone equally."

Cheongpung, who had been watching blankly, looked at me with sparkling eyes.

"Oh. I don't really understand, but it sounds cool."

“It’s nothing special… Anyway, thanks.”

I might have said more, but there was no time.

The five bastards—or rather, the five sons and daughters of bitches—had jumped down from the second floor.

Tap.

They landed lightly, as befitted First Rate masters. One of them stepped out from the group as they glared at us.

Level 45. Tall and good-looking. The same bastard who had laughed first.

“I am—”

“You the head?”

“The head?”

“Are you the boss of these five?”

He let out a short laugh.

“You’d better watch your mouth. If you knew who the people here were, including me…”

I smiled back and scanned through their Level windows.

“Seongryong, Cheonwoo, Myeonghwa, Sohye, and finally, you—Jintae. Want me to tell you your family names, too?”

“…!”

“…!”

Five pairs of astonished eyes turned toward me. No, seven, counting Hyuk Mujin and Cheongpung.

“Oh, and this is a personal request, but please don’t ask how I knew. I’m sick of that line. If you ask, I’ll hit you.”

“How did you…?”

“Did you stuff radishes in your ears?”

The next moment, my palm met his cheek.

Smack!

Chapter 134

Smack!

Woo Jintae's head snapped to the side with a satisfying crack. He blankly stroked his cheek.

What just happened?

He was dumbfounded. Had he just been slapped? By a punk like this?

Woo Jintae was nearly thirty. He had married young and already had a family of his own.

Yet some kid who barely looked twenty had subjected him to such humiliation.

"Eek! Young Hero Woo!"

"H-Hyung[789], are you all right?"

"Isn't that the Young Bureau Head of the Seongun Escort Bureau?"

"That's him. My goodness, what kind of reckless bastard would… Wait. Doesn't that face look familiar?"

The young prodigies' belated reactions and the stares of the inn's guests doubled Woo Jintae's shame.

He glared at the little bastard before him, his eyes brimming with killing intent.

"How dare you…"

"That's not what you should be saying."

"What?"

"Not *how dare you*. You should be asking *how did you do that?* If you're a martial artist."

Woo Jintae froze for a moment.

Since childhood, he had received the full support of the Seongun Escort Bureau, taking in all kinds of elixirs and First Rate martial arts. Even if he hadn't been born with extraordinary martial talent, it was only natural that he took pride in being a move and a half ahead of the other young prodigies.

How did someone like me get beaten so easily?

He hadn't even seen when or how the bastard approached. The humiliation of being utterly disgraced in front of everyone had overwhelmed everything else.

Only then did Woo Jintae study his opponent with eyes full of caution.

"Look at those eyes darting around. What, do you want me to tell you my three measurements[790]?"

"Who are you, and what sect are you from?"

"I'm Tien Shinhan of the Dodong Sect, you son of a bitch."

---

[789] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or an older man with whom he is familiar.

[790] The "three measurements" are bust, waist, and hip measurements.

Woo Jintae endured the young bastard's profanity only because he had finally regained his reason.

In the Murim, you never knew what might happen. If the other man was a disciple of a great sect, Woo Jintae would have to withdraw cleanly.

The Dodong Sect? Tien Shinhan of the Dodong Sect?

Both the sect and the man's name were utterly unfamiliar. Woo Jintae glanced behind him and saw the same bewilderment on the other young prodigies' faces.

His mind raced.

As far as I know, there's no such sect as the Dodong Sect in Shanxi Province.

Opening a new sect in Shanxi Province, where all the established sects had already secured their positions, was nearly impossible.

Even setting aside interference from the other sects, word of it would spread immediately.

If they raised a young prodigy of this level at his age, the sect must possess considerable power... Where could it be? Shaanxi? Henan?

As Woo Jintae found himself unable to speak, his eyes darting around, the young martial artist who had been standing idly by as though none of this concerned him suddenly asked,

"What's the Dodong Sect? Is it a real sect?"

"Would it be? A well-told lie becomes fact."

"Ah. I'll engrave those golden words in my heart."

"You little punk. You're talking pretty for once."

A young man dressed in rags like a beggar added his own comment.

"A well-told lie becomes fact... Those are wise words. I can sense profound mysteries in them."

"Ah... yes. Thank you for the compliment, at least."

Sparks flew from Woo Jintae's eyes as he listened to the three of them.

"You bastard! Reveal your identity!"

"Why? So you can hear who I am and where I'm from, pick a fight if I sound like an easy target, then tuck your tail between your legs and apologize if my status is too high?"

"..."

Crude as it was, the remark hit the mark. When Woo Jintae couldn't answer, the young bastard clicked his tongue.

"Punk, you started with the wrong question. They say the one who farted gets angry. If you wanted an answer from me, you should've apologized first."

Woo Jintae bit down on his lip.

An apology?

Born the sole male heir the Seongun Escort Bureau's family had produced in three generations, he had spent his entire life being pampered and revered. He wasn't flexible enough to bow his head to some nobody of unknown origin.

At last, Woo Jintae made up his mind and gave the young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi a subtle signal with his eyes.

No matter how strong he is, he can't be that strong.

There were only three opponents. On their side were five First Rate masters, all among Shanxi Province's foremost young prodigies.

Seeing the four men and women discreetly gripping their weapons in response to his signal, Woo Jintae felt reassured.

"Do you know who I am—or rather, who we are?"

"I happen to know your names, at least. But is that an apology?"

"An apology? You've got some nerve."

Woo Jintae sneered.

"We are the heirs of the Five Gates of Shanxi. Surely you can't claim not to know the Five Gates of Shanxi."

"I'll say I know. But are you really not going to apologize? This is your final warning."

"I'll warn you, too. I don't know where you came from, but you picked the wrong person to mess with—"

Smack!

Woo Jintae's vision flashed white.

He stumbled backward instinctively as lightning-fast slaps struck him one after another.

Smack! Smack! Smack-smack!

One slap with every step.

After taking five slaps in all, Woo Jintae staggered.

The relentless blows had struck only one side of his face, leaving his cheek grotesquely swollen and blood pooling inside his split mouth.

Even my father has never hit me.

It was the first humiliation of his life—and it had happened in front of everyone.

His eyes rolled wildly.

"You fucking—!"

"I told you, final warning. Do you not know what *final* means, or what *warning* means? Or both?"

"How dare you hit me?"

"I may be the first man ever to treat you so casually, but please don't fall in love with me. I'm busy enough loving one Song-i."

"I'll kill you!"

“I’ll beat you!”

Smack-smack-smack!

“Guh!”

Woo Jintae couldn’t regain his senses.

The blows carried no internal energy, nor did his opponent seem to be using any mysterious manoeuvre technique. Yet he had no way to block the storm of slaps raining down on both cheeks.

How is this possible?

As he was beaten helplessly, a crazed shout rang in his ears.

“Slap with the left hand, slap with the right hand!”

Smack-smack!

“One chi[791], two chi[792], three chi[793], four chi[794]—Ppukku cheek! Ppukku cheek!”

Smack-smack-smack!

He kept shouting words that made no sense while flinging slap after slap. He looked like a madman born for the sole purpose of smacking people across the face.

Just like right now.

“Raise your left hand and lower your right. Lower your right and lower your left. Lower your left, and don’t raise your right.”

“Hurk!”

“That’s right. Good job. As a reward, your teacher is going to give little Woo Jintae’s cheeks a thorough beating.”

Smack-smack-smack-smack!

How many times had he been struck in the space of less than a moment?

Thirty? Fifty?

He had been hit so frantically that his head rang and tears swam in his eyes.

In the end, all Woo Jintae could do was call for help.

“P-please! Somebody help me!”

[791] A Korean *chi* is a traditional unit of length equal to 3.03 cm (1.19 in). The line plays on a Korean counting chant.

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The Young Bureau Head of the Seongun Escort Bureau—the very Seongun Escort Bureau whose wealth alone was said to rival that of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, the richest family in Shanxi—cried out in desperation.

“P-please help me!”

Yet even after Woo Jintae cast aside his pride and everything else, the young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi couldn’t bring themselves to draw their weapons.

“How are we supposed to beat that…?”

The words slipped from someone like a groan, speaking for them all.

They were right. There was no need to experience it firsthand.

Just watching from the side was enough to make their knees go weak and their legs give out. Their opponent was roughly the same age as them, but there was no question that he was a master far beyond their imagination.

“To reach that realm at his age…”

“That thing’s a complete monster.”

Smack-smack!

“P-please spare my life!”

Woo Jintae’s voice grew even more desperate. Even his plea for help had subtly changed.

If this continued much longer, he might start begging to be killed instead.

“W-we should help him, right?”

“At the very least, we should try to stop him… Young Master Wang, do something.”

“Me? Why me all of a sudden?”

“Why do you think? Every time we got together, you bragged about your family’s martial arts. You said it was sword arts you could display anywhere in the Central Plains without shame.”

The heir of the Wang Family Estate, who never missed an opportunity to boast about the greatness of his family’s martial arts, answered with a solemn expression.

“I’m a saber user. I never learned sword arts.”

“What?”

“And why are you trying to dump this on me? If Young Lady Shin wants to stop him so badly, she can step in herself.”

“My goodness. What a spectacle.”

As the young prodigies of the Five Gates passed the responsibility around, Hyuk Mujin, who had been quietly watching the situation, suddenly cut in.

“You’re all worrying over nothing. If it were me, I’d hurry over and lend a hand, at least.”

“You—no, sir. Who are you?”

With such a terrifying scene unfolding before them, they had to speak with even an ordinary martial artist using half-polite language.

Young Lady Hwang, who had received Shu brocade as a gift from Woo Jintae only a quarter of an hour earlier, quickly stepped forward.

“Let me make this clear in advance. We have no ill feelings toward you people. You know that, right?”

“Do you? If that’s how it is, then fine. Let’s say that’s how it is.”

“I’m not saying we should just say that. I’m saying it’s the truth.”

“What good will telling me do?”

Hyuk Mujin grinned and jerked his chin toward Jin Taekyung’s back, where he was enthusiastically beating Woo Jintae.

“Our Captain has quite a temper. Once the gentleman getting beaten over there collapses, who do you think will be next? You, Young Master? Or the Young Lady beside you?”

“…”

“Oh, and just in case you’re wondering, that man hits men and women alike.”

“I-I didn’t laugh!”

“Neither did I!”

“Do I have to say the same thing twice? Telling me won’t do you any good. Though, there is one way that might work.”

“A way?”

The young prodigies’ ears perked up.

They hadn’t trained in martial arts for nothing. They understood that they had no chance against that monstrous young man.

“S-somebody save me…”

Woo Jintae’s dying voice happened to drift into their ears, fanning their survival instincts even further.

“W-what exactly is this way?”

Hyuk Mujin stroked his chin with a deliberately serious expression.

“Well, you’re all scions of influential families, so I don’t know whether you can bring yourselves to do it.”

“I will!”

“I’ll do it! I’ll definitely do it!”

“Good. At least you’ve got the right attitude.”

Hyuk Mujin nodded in satisfaction and pointed at Cheongpung, who was watching the one-sided beating with his mouth hanging open.

“First, apologize politely to this gentleman.”

Before he had even finished speaking, the young men and women of the Five Gates bent deeply at the waist.

“We sincerely apologize.”

“We’re truly sorry for judging you rashly based on your appearance.”

Cheongpung scratched the back of his head.

“I’m fine, so everyone, please stand up.”

Considering how they had mocked him in front of so many people, Cheongpung forgave them so readily that even Hyuk Mujin was taken aback.

Even his face, which should rightfully have been flushed with anger, was sunny and bright.

“You’re saying that so easily?”

“Yes. Is there a problem?”

“It’s not that, but… Weren’t you angry earlier? You were insulted so publicly.”

“Why would I be angry? I just found it fascinating.”

“What? What do you mean?”

“That was the first time so many people had paid attention to me. It was also the first time someone who looked down on me apologized afterward. I found it fascinating and fun.”

“…”

“Ah. I think coming down from the mountain was a good decision.”

This guy’s a little nuts, too.

Hyuk Mujin looked at Cheongpung as though he were some strange creature, then shook his head and turned to the young prodigies.

“You heard him, right? Since Cheongpung here has accepted your apology, we’ll consider the matter settled.”

“Oh!”

“We’re saved!”

But Hyuk Mujin wasn’t finished.

“All right, then. There’s one final thing left—the second.”

“…The second?”

“There’s more?”

“Yes. This is the most important one.”

Then he solemnly declared to the four men and women looking at him,

“All of you, get down and plant your heads on the floor.”

“…!”

“…!”

Chapter 135

Smack!

“P-please, help me!”

“No one’s coming to help you.”

Smack-smack!

“P-please, spare me!”

“Nope. Not happening. Go away.”

Smack-smack-smack!

“Th-then just kill me…”

“No, you’re still fine. Words are still coming out of your mouth.”

Smack-smack-smack-smack!

“Hhk… Hhrrgh…”

“Yes. That’s the reaction I was looking for.”

Only then did I finally stop.

The young master’s once reasonably presentable face had puffed up like a steamed bun. Instead of a rosy flush, dark blue bruises covered both cheeks.

“Our Jintae. Did you do something wrong or not?”

“Hhrrgh.”

Seeing him sob in such a miserable state, I suddenly felt a little sorry for him.

Right. He’s someone else’s precious son, too…

“You did something wrong, didn’t you?”

“Hhk! Hhrrgh!”

“Then why did you ignore what I was saying? You should’ve apologized the moment I told you to. Wouldn’t that have been better? Don’t you think?”

“Hhrrr.”

“Let’s be good from now on. Understand?”

“Hhrrgh.”

I quietly watched Woo Jintae nod furiously, then spoke.

“But you…”

“Hh?”

“Why have you been answering like that this whole time? Can’t you speak like a person?”

His sobbing stopped dead.

“I-I’m sorry.”

“So you can talk. You could talk all along, but you chose not to? Why were you crying? Were you trying to show how much pain and hardship you were in?”

“No!”

“Now your voice is getting louder, too. You’ve got some volume. Have you been practicing diaphragmatic breathing? Were you planning to burst my eardrums and escape this crisis?”

“No. Absolutely not. Please, stop now. Hh-hhng…”

“Oh? You’re crying again? You can still cry? What have you done to deserve tears? Is your life over because you’re crying? And ‘please stop’? Anyone watching would think I was the one attacking you.”

“I’m sorry. I won’t cry.”

“Wow, look at him stop crying right away. You’re a creepy bastard, aren’t you? If I were you, I’d feel so guilty for picking on an innocent person that I’d cry until I passed out from exhaustion. Are you really sorry?”

“P-please, just listen to me for a moment…”

“Listen to what? Do you even have the right to speak? Is this some kind of entertainment awards ceremony? Am I supposed to wait quietly while you talk, then smile warmly and applaud when you’re finished?”

“…”

“Now you’re not even answering. You must feel full even without eating. Right? If you keep crunching through other people’s words like that, it must feel good…”

Just as I was about to continue, Woo Jintae slammed the back of his head into the floor with lightning speed.

Thud! Flop.

What a shame. I could have kept chewing him out for at least another shichen.[795]

As I turned away from the unconscious Woo Jintae, countless gazes came flying toward me and stuck fast.

“The Young Bureau Head of the Seongun Escort Bureau went down that easily…”

“Who the hell is that young man?”

“His hands are vicious enough, but his tongue is a venomous snake all on its own.”

Murmurs of shock and fear rippled through the room.

There were around a hundred guests on the first floor alone. It was hardly surprising that some of them recognized me.

“I-it’s the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

“What? The one from the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“Do you think there are two Sleeping Dragons of Shanxi? I knew he looked familiar.”

My reputation as the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi really does shake the heavens.

I was just about to give the crowd a pleased smile and wave when someone spoke up.

[795] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

“Are you sure? I saw the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi at Honghwaru around this time last year, but he looks a little…”

“You don’t remember that the two of us were there together?”

“Oh. Were we?”

“Yes. His build and overall impression have changed quite a bit, but it’s definitely him. I can still picture that young master from the Jin Family making a scene because he wanted to bring a courtesan back to the family.”

“…”

Damn. Why do people remember such useless things?

As I awkwardly lowered my hand, several guests who had been whispering among themselves suddenly raised theirs.

“I was there, too!”

“You were, Brother?”

“I remember it clearly. That bastard—no, that gentleman—fell down the stairs, grabbed the thing between my legs, and gave it a long yank… Whew. Just thinking about it still makes me dizzy.”

“My goodness, how indecent. Are you all right now?”

“Fortunately, I’m perfectly fine. Not only that, I think it’s gotten a little longer since then.”

“…”

Can that happen?

I barely suppressed the urge to ask exactly how much longer it had gotten. I still had the trash from the so-called Five Gates of Shanxi to deal with.

But then…

“Huh?”

Four young prodigies were lined up with their heads planted on the floor, while Hyuk Mujin stood beside them with his neck held strangely stiff.

“We’re ready.”

“Did you order them to do this?”

“They say even a village-school dog can recite poetry after three years. By now, I can tell what you want at a glance.”

“You little…”

I was seized by an indescribable emotion.

At first, I’d thought he was an idiot, but he seemed to be getting smarter by the day.

I was starting to suspect he was putting points into Intelligence on my behalf.

“You’ve grown. I’m very proud of you.”

“You’re too kind. More importantly, what should we do with them?”

“Give me the sword case.”

“At your command.”

It was straight out of a historical drama. I took the sword case Hyuk Mujin held out and slapped it against my palm.

Good grip. Good impact, too.

“Everyone, on your feet.”

The four young prodigies sprang to their feet the moment I spoke.

Ignoring their terrified gazes, I scanned their Level Windows again. Just as I’d thought, they were barely First Rate, if that.

“You already know what you did wrong… You’re the heirs of the Five Gates of Shanxi?”

“Y-yes, sir!”

“You’re not third sons or youngest daughters or anything like that?”

“No, sir!”

“You’re sure?”

“Yes, sir!”

Their voices, filled with proper martial spirit, rang through the inn. I tapped the sword case against my palm and muttered,

“Really? Then the Five Gates of Shanxi aren’t anything special, are they?”

“…”

“…”

Every one of their faces flushed with shame, but none of them dared to answer.

They knew who I was now.

The difference in our martial prowess aside, the Five Gates of Shanxi couldn’t hold their heads high before the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“You’ve had it good all this time, haven’t you?”

“…No, sir.”

“What do you mean, no? You never had to worry about money, and you had powerful backing. You relied on that and strutted around like big shots, didn’t you? Picking fights wherever you went.”

“…”

“But then a war broke out between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect. The Jin Family was the one that had always treated you well, but you were afraid of the retaliation that would come if Mount Heng won, so you kept watching the situation and ended up here. Right?”

“Th-that’s… We…”

“You’re the heirs, aren’t you? Young Sect Leaders, Lesser Family Heads, things like that. Ah, that fellow over there was the Young Bureau Head.”

The four of them reflexively followed my finger and shuddered.

Unable to withstand the merciless barrage of slaps and trash talk, Woo Jintae had chosen to knock himself unconscious. He lay on the floor like a corpse.

“Anyway, given the situation, you should’ve kept your heads down. What did you come all the way here for, acting so high and mighty? Do you think the Jin Family of Taiyuan is a joke? Do I need to tattoo ‘Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi’ on my forehead and walk around with it?”

“I-I’m sorry.”

“Does apologizing make everything go away? Should I beat you into a bloody mess and then apologize to you?”

“Eek!”

Just look at those terrified eyes. I felt like a walking disaster.

There was no need for any more words. I raised the sword case.

“Historically, this has always been the best medicine. Everyone, get down.”

Then I asked the four trembling young prodigies lying face down before me in a chilling voice,

“How many blows will it take for you to reflect? Each of you, give me a number.”

“W-what?”

“Give me a number. I beat that Woo Jintae so badly because he was acting too high and mighty. Since you paid up voluntarily, I’ll take that into consideration.”

A heavy silence descended.

The four exchanged hurried glances, then shouted in unison.

“J-just one!”

“One? Will that really be enough?”

“Yes, sir!”

“If you take one hit, will you swear never to do anything like this again?”

“We swear it before Heaven and Earth and all the divine spirits!”

I tightened my grip on the sword case.

“Good. Then ten each.”

“…!”

“…!”

“I just asked Heaven and Earth, and they said one wouldn’t come close to being enough for you. So ten it is.”

I never thought I’d find myself in a situation like this.

I felt like one of those physical-education entrance-exam instructors from my school days who swung a bat whenever he got the chance.

Sinking into a strange sense of nostalgia, I swung the bat—or rather, the sword case.

Whack! Whack! Whack! Crack!

"Guh!"

"Don't move. You'll hurt your bones. All right, again."

Whack! Whack! Whack!

It must have been a rare sight for everyone packed into Honghwa Inn. The heirs of the Five Gates of Shanxi were crawling across the floor like grubs.

Two of them were even women.

The whispers of the people surrounding us cut into my ears.

"Is that really okay?"

"I know, right? Even if they are the Five Gates of Shanxi… Couldn't this turn into another one of those big fights over Murim gratitude and grudges?"

"Don't be so clueless. Are you really that out of touch with what's happening these days? Maybe things would be different if the Mount Heng Sword Sect were still standing, but now, every small and medium-sized sect in Shanxi could join forces and still might not stop the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"It's that bad?"

"They might outnumber them if they gathered everyone, but the caliber is completely different. You only have to look at the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi over there to see that."

"That's true. Those Five Gates heirs swaggered around like big shots, but they're nothing before the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

"If you think about it, they were the ones who picked the fight first."

"That's true, too."

"And since we're on the subject, there's something rotten about everyone calling themselves the Five Gates of Shanxi these days."

"Rotten?"

"They call themselves an orthodox faction, but they're really just sucking the marrow out of ordinary people without anyone noticing. Just look at the Seongun Escort Bureau. How many complaints have merchants made about them?"

"Were all those rumors true?"

"What about the Jin Family of Taiyuan? When famine struck ten years ago, they released relief grain. Long before that, they even held off the Demonic Cult. Those bastards were vicious murderous fiends who went around killing ordinary people like us. If not for the Jin Family of Taiyuan… Ugh. I don't even want to think about it."

"That's right. I also heard it was the Jin Family of Taiyuan that drove off the mounted bandits who crossed over from Gaoyuan this time."

"Is there anyone who hasn't heard that rumor yet? They say the Heaven Shaking Sword and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi slaughtered every last one of them."

"My goodness."

"So even if another war breaks out, what's there to worry about? I swear, if the Five Gates of Shanxi try to make an issue of this, I'll join the Jin Family of Taiyuan immediately and fight!"

"Oh!"

"That's some impressive chivalrous spirit for such a young man. Now that I've heard you out, I think you're right. Here, have a drink on me!"

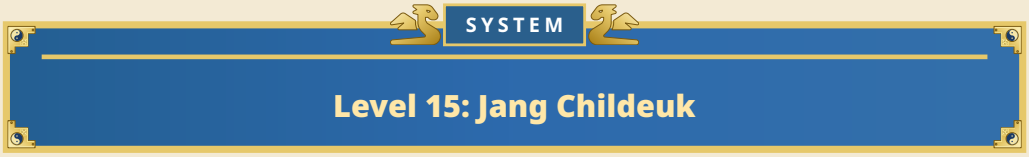
Whack! Whack! Whack!

After turning three of the four young prodigies into grubs, I turned toward the voices.

The speaker had defended the Jin Family of Taiyuan so passionately that, by the time he finished, I wanted to buy him a drink myself.

In terms of mindset, he's already one of our Jin Family.

If his Level were high enough, he'd be my first recruitment pick. Smiling with satisfaction, I checked the great orator's Level Window.



"…What the fuck?"

Jang Childeuk? The Jang Childeuk I know?

Looking again, I realized I definitely recognized him.

He was the servant who had faithfully brought us meals while I was receiving one-on-one intensive training from Jin Mukyung.

That Jang Childeuk was the great orator's true identity.

Holy shit. Goose bumps.

No wonder he'd been taking the Jin Family's side so aggressively.

Nothing he'd said was wrong, of course, but manipulating public opinion like this…

I was trembling as though I'd uncovered some enormous political conspiracy when someone spoke.

"Um…"

It was Cheongpung, the one person I had momentarily forgotten. He spoke up, his eyes clear.

"There's still one person left."

"Ah."

The last man lying face down flinched. Cheongpung seemed innocent in his own way, but he was also strangely frightening.

Not that I had any intention of going easy on him just because he was last.

"I was just about to hit him."

I was about to swing the sword case when Cheongpung spoke again.
“Excuse me. May I ask you one difficult favor?”
“We’re out of candied hawthorn skewers[796] now.”
“That’s not it. I, uh…”
Cheongpung hesitated, then quietly pointed at the sword case.
“I’d like to try hitting the last gentleman.”
“What?”
“I’ve never done anything like this before…”
“…”
I had seen every kind of nutcase in my life, but this was my first time seeing a first-experience villain.

[796]Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack of fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

Chapter 136

“Ugh.”

“Gnnngh.”

The two men’s eyes met as they groaned. Seeing each other lying face down with their bare buttocks exposed was embarrassing, yet it also gave them a strange sense of solidarity.

“Ahem. Young Hero Jeong, how are your wounds?”

“Ahem. More or less. How about you, Young Hero Gal?”

“I feel like I’m going to die—hngh!”

“Actually, so do I—ngh!”

The pain returned as they spoke. Both men blinked back tears and muttered,

“There’s bad luck, and then there’s this. Of all the people we could have run into, why did it have to be the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“I know. I never thought I’d suffer this kind of humiliation in my lifetime.”

The mood was gloomy.

Things might have been different in the Central Plains, where countless prestigious sects stood shoulder to shoulder. But in borderland Shanxi Province, both men were heirs to sects big enough to swagger around spitting and farting as they pleased.

They had never once had to humble themselves before anyone. Now they lay groaning in bed after being thoroughly beaten.

“Even when the Mount Heng Sword Sect was still standing, the Five Gates of Shanxi weren’t reduced to this…”

“Those were the days.”

A few months ago, the alliance of small and medium-sized sects led by the Five Gates of Shanxi could still have made its voice heard. Now, they couldn’t even squeak. The balance of Shanxi Murim had been shattered.

With the fall of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, the balance of power in Shanxi Murim was bound to tilt toward the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“My father will kill me if he finds out.”

“Same here. He warned me so many times. If he finds out this happened… Ugh. I don’t even want to think about it.”

They had been publicly humiliated in front of more than a hundred people. By around New Year’s Day, the rumor would certainly have spread throughout all of Shanxi.

“If I had my way, I’d run far away.”

“To hell with running away. I don’t even know if I’ll be able to walk tomorrow. But I can’t refuse the City Lord’s summons, either…”

“Even if our legs are broken, we still have to go. What else can we do? He isn’t just some ordinary City Lord. He’s a member of the imperial family.”

“That’s true. At least our faces are fine.”

“They are.”

Their gazes naturally shifted to the side.

Woo Jintae lay there as though dead, his face swollen like he had been stung by a swarm of wasps. If not for the occasional labored breath, they would have thought he was already dead.

“Still, how could anyone beat a man that badly?”

“I never knew the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi was this vicious.”

“Thank goodness we planted our heads on the floor beforehand. We almost ended up just like Brother Woo.”

“He absolutely would have done it. Isn’t he the bastard who beats women without mercy, too?”

There were two women in their group. A man might be expected to go soft in front of young, beautiful women, but that bastard Jin Taekyung’s reaction had gone far beyond anything they expected.

“Age.”

“Y-yes?”

“Age. How old are you?”

“I-I’m seventeen.”

“And you?”

“I-I’m eighteen.”

Seventeen and eighteen. They were in the flower of youth, old enough that it wouldn’t have been strange for talk of marriage to begin.

Just as everyone wondered whether Jin Taekyung might be interested in the women—

“Lift your butt higher. You’ll break a bone.”

Whack! Whack!

“You kids are still wet behind the ears! And you’re already drinking!”

Whack! Whack!

“If you’re going to drink, hide somewhere and do it quietly! Don’t pick a fight with someone who was minding his own business!”

Whack! Whack!

“You haven’t learned how to behave! People like you are exactly why corporal punishment is necessary! Do you understand or not?”

Whack! Whack!

“Improve teacher authority! A certain amount of corporal punishment is absolutely necessary!”

Whack! Whack! Whack!

The two men shuddered at the memory.

One woman had fainted, while the other had wept until tears and snot streamed down her face in front of everyone.

After having their buttocks thoroughly beaten by a man outside their families in front of so many people, it was only a matter of time before their marriage prospects were ruined.

“What in the world does ‘improve teacher authority’ mean? Is it something from Mencius[797]?”

“I don’t know, either. He even hit them one extra time.”

“What a vicious bastard…”

“Even so, I envy the others.”

“What kind of outrageous thing is that to say? Can’t you see that your butt is covered in bruises?”

“At least the others were beaten by the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. I was beaten by some beggar-looking bastard… Sob!”

“Oh, that’s awful.”

“If I’d been beaten by the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, at least I could make excuses. But some mangy bastard who crawled in from who-knows-where beat my butt… Who borrows a beating instead of money?”

His chin trembled with humiliation as he remembered the beggar-like man taking the sword case from Jin Taekyung and gleefully laying into him.

“Wow, this is fun! Your butt has some great bounce!”

Whack! Whack! Whack!

“Does it hurt? How much does it hurt? If you don’t mind, may I hit you harder? This is my first time doing something like this, so please understand if I’m not very good at controlling my strength!”

Whack! Whack! Whack!

He had suffered a humiliation he would never forget until the day he died—or even after. He wanted to chew that bastard up from head to toe and swallow him piece by piece, and even that wouldn’t have been enough.

“I will never forgive that bastard!”

“Don’t worry. I’ll do everything in my power to help you, Young Hero Jeong!”

Who were they? They were heirs to the Five Gates of Shanxi. Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan might be beyond their reach, but they certainly had enough power to deal with one young beggar.

“Um, about that…”

---

[797] Mencius was an ancient Chinese philosopher whose teachings became part of the Confucian tradition.

"Yes?"

"Are you certain he's really a beggar? I'm not saying this because I'm afraid, but after what happened with the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, it occurs to me that there's no harm in being thorough…"

"…Should we look into him a little more?"

"Y-yes. Let's do that."

One group beating had taught the pampered rich kids to be cautious.

Once the lesson was over, we decided to move to a private room.

Staying on the first floor meant enduring the stares of all the surrounding guests.

Basking in people's attention was fun for a moment or two, but if I tried to eat like this, I'd probably lose track of whether the food was going into my mouth or up my nose.

"My name is Seok, and I oversee Honghwa Inn. Please feel free to call me Chief Steward Seok."

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi's reputation really was something. The chief steward, who hadn't shown so much as a hair until now, had come out personally to bow to me.

This man must be part of the Lower District Sect, too, right?

Honghwaru served as the base of Wolhwa, Chief Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect in Shanxi, and judging by its name, Honghwa Inn was practically a subordinate organization.

He might even have known about my existence before I set foot inside Honghwa Inn.

I can't say that makes me feel particularly good.

Was it overreacting to think that unseen gazes were monitoring my every move?

Still, I wasn't exactly offended.

It was more like a little caution. We had certainly maintained a friendly relationship until now, but no one knew what might happen in the future.

"I've prepared a separate, quiet place for you."

"Oh, that sounds good."

They were offering us special treatment without even being asked, so there was no reason to refuse. I was about to follow the chief steward when—

"Thank you for everything, Benefactor."

I turned toward the voice and found Cheongpung smiling innocently.

"What do you mean? Surely you aren't planning to leave just like this?"

"Yes. It's already late, so I was thinking of heading out."

Going where? We barely got to talk because those random bastards barged in.

I hurriedly waved him off.

“Come on, if it’s late, you should stay the night. You said you don’t have any travel money, right?”

“It’s all right. I’m used to sleeping rough.”

“You shouldn’t be used to that. Right, a new experience! Have you ever slept at an inn?”

“I stayed at inns a few times before I lost my travel money. And I’ve already imposed on you both more than enough.”

Hyuk Mujin muttered beside me.

“That’s true. My candied hawthorn skewers[798]…”

“You be quiet. So, are you really leaving?”

“Yes. Fortunately, I still have business left in Shanxi Province, so if we happen to get the chance, we’ll meet again.”

At this point, I had nothing left to say. If a Peak master was determined to leave of his own accord, I couldn’t exactly hold him back by claiming the roads were dangerous at night.

Still, I was dying to know the identity of this oddball who had suddenly appeared out of nowhere.

“If you have nowhere to go, come to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Give them my name and they’ll let you in.”

“Oh, come to think of it, you’re a Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, aren’t you? The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung… I’ll remember my Benefactor’s name.”

He had known who I was for some time, but it hadn’t fazed him in the slightest. His reaction amounted to, *Oh, I see.* That was it.

Hyuk Mujin subtly caught my eye before cutting in.

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan. You don’t know it?”

“Well, I think I’ve heard of it somewhere. It does sound familiar, but I don’t really know much about it.”

Cheongpung tilted his head for a moment, then bowed to us.

“If fate brings us together, we’ll meet again. Then I’ll be off.”

I bid him farewell with deep regret.

“Take care. And don’t forget the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Haha, of course I won’t.”

He turned away with a hearty laugh. Thinking the conversation was over, the chief steward spoke.

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[798] A sweet made by coating skewered hawthorn fruit in hardened sugar.

“Then I’ll escort you to the annex.”

“Ah, yes. Mujin, let’s go.”

“Oh! We get to sleep in the annex of the famous Honghwa Inn?”

“We stayed in the annex at Phoenix Inn, too. Why are you acting like this is something new?”

“What are you talking about? If Phoenix Inn is a young prodigy, then Honghwa Inn is a Peak master whose fame is already known. Its hot springs, in particular, are such a renowned attraction that even high officials and nobles visit them.”

“Hot springs?”

“I’ve only heard about them from rumors, but they say there’s no paradise like it.”

The chief steward added calmly,

“My father is turning eighty this year. He came here once and nearly departed for paradise.”

“…Isn’t that dangerous?”

“It only means the hot springs are that good. He’s still hale and hearty.”

“Ah, I see. I hope he lives a long life.”

Hot springs…

I had gone to saunas plenty of times, but I had never visited a hot spring. Just thinking about sinking into pleasantly hot water already had me excited.

“Ahem. Shall we go?”

“I’ll escort you.”

I was just about to follow the chief steward when a firm hand suddenly seized my shoulder.

“Um. Did you just say hot springs?”

“…You haven’t left yet?”

Looking at Cheongpung’s sheepish grin, I was certain of one thing.

I’d bet both my balls this bastard had never been to a hot spring.

In the early dawn, while darkness still lay thick over the estate’s training ground, a man was swinging a sword.

He looked to be about thirty. His strong, rugged features were striking.

Swish, swish, swish!

He thrust, slashed, and swung without pause. Each form flowed smoothly into the next, like flower petals fluttering in the wind.

As the Seven Plum Sword, in which he had reached eight-tenths mastery, cut through the chilly dawn air, a messenger opened the main gate and entered.

“What is it? I forbade anyone from entering while I’m training.”

“My apologies. But His Highness Prince Shangshan ordered me to deliver a message…”

“His Highness?”

“Yes. His Highness commands you to attend today’s luncheon at noon.”

“The luncheon… You mean the gathering where the young prodigies of Murim are coming?”

“Yes, sir.”

The man let out a deep sigh. He was a Third-Rank Assistant Military Commissioner, an official who could easily be counted among the five highest-ranking figures in Shanxi Province.

I can’t refuse an order from His Highness. What a nuisance.

The position of Assistant Military Commissioner was by no means an idle one. It was a weighty office responsible for training the soldiers.

But the order had come from Prince Shangshan, the City Lord and a man of royal blood. The man had no choice but to nod.

“Tell His Highness that I accept the royal command.”

“Yes, sir!”

After the messenger departed, the man raised his sword once more.

As he resumed the Seven Plum Sword, the plum blossoms of Huashan, which he had left long ago, seemed to bloom from his blade.

Chapter 137

“Are you awake?”

A familiar face abruptly opened the annex door and barged in.

I had just finished circulating my qi, so I unfolded my legs from the lotus position and spoke.

“You came in without even waiting for an answer?”

“Come on, Captain. You and I aren’t that distant.”

“What kind of relationship do you and I have?”

“Comrades in arms who don’t share blood but can fight back-to-back? A lord-and-vassal relationship tightly bound by affection and trust?”

“Affection? Hmm. You’re determined to get beaten half to death first thing in the morning.”

“One hit, then. Surely it won’t kill me.”

He was getting more shameless by the day. I let out a quiet laugh and shook my head.

“Enough. What brings you here so early?”

“Obviously… Wait, what’s with that guy? Did he sleep here?”

Hyuk Mujin stared incredulously at Cheongpung, who lay sprawled in the corner.

“Why would he sleep here when the annex has several rooms?”

“Leave him alone. It happens. I came back from the privy and found him asleep.”

Long story short, my attempt to uncover Cheongpung’s identity had ended in complete failure.

The moment he got out of the hot spring, he had fallen asleep from exhaustion. I couldn’t bring myself to wake him, so I slept, too.

“Even so, Captain. How could you let a strange man you met yesterday sleep in your room?”

“…That sounded a little strange.”

“That’s not what I meant. I’m saying you should be more careful.”

“Careful? Anyone listening to you would think he was an assassin.”

“Can you say for certain he isn’t?”

“What?”

“You’re a good man in many ways, Captain, but I think you take the Murim too lightly. It’s a place tangled in complicated gratitude and grudges. Let your guard down, and you could really end up dead.”

“What an unlucky thing to say. Want me to send you there?”

“Seriously! I’m not joking.”

Mujin thumped his chest in frustration, then watched the sleeping Cheongpung with wary eyes.

"Isn't he a little strange? He seems remarkably skilled for someone so young, yet he wanders around looking like a beggar. And he isn't even a Disciple of the Beggars' Sect."

"Maybe that's just the way he's wired."

"What if all of that is just a disguise meant to lower people's guard? If he were a trained assassin, it would be entirely possible."

"An assassin? Who would even want to target me?"

"Why wouldn't anyone?"

"You know I'm not such a bastard that I make people hold grudges against me everywhere I go."

"…Just counting yesterday, I think at least five people now have a grudge against you."

Come to think of it, he had a point.

Still, suspecting Cheongpung of being an assassin was an overreaction.

I spoke to Mujin, who was still shooting Cheongpung suspicious glances.

"This guy isn't one. If he were an assassin, would I still be alive?"

"Well, that's true."

"And what assassin? Aside from those Five Gates of Shanxi bastards, who could possibly have a reason to hold a grudge against me?"

"Did the Head Elder try to kill you because of some personal grudge? What about the martial artists of our family who died in the last war?"

"That… is true."

Mujin shook his head.

"I'm only telling you to be careful. Gratitude and grudges in the Murim run deep and stay hidden, so no one knows when or where something might happen."

"Hmm."

"Flies swarm around appetizing food. The more famous the name Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi becomes, the more trouble you'll have to deal with. There are even people who show up out of nowhere and challenge you to a life-and-death duel."

The world was a big place, and there were plenty of lunatics in it. I was surprised to hear something I'd never heard of, but I was also impressed by Mujin.

This guy is saying something genuinely useful for once.

"You know quite a lot. What a good boy."

"Ahem. It's nothing worth making a fuss over. I've just seen a lot of things."

As expected of a local. People in the Murim around my age had apparently seen assassins killing people and all kinds of other things.

“Does that sort of thing happen all the time in the Murim? You know, you go out to the market and see martial artists picking fights with each other?”

“What?”

Mujin blinked.

“What are you talking about? This is Taiyuan. The public order is excellent.”

“Oh. So not often, but sometimes?”

“Sometimes? I lived in Taiyuan for nearly twenty years before entering the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and I never once saw martial artists fighting each other.”

“…What?”

“The Shanxi Provincial Office, where the City Lord resides, is half a shichen[799] west of here, and the Jin Family of Taiyuan is one shichen[800] east. Starting a sword fight for no reason would only make your life miserable. Even the lowest wandering martial artists pretend to be Great Heroes of Benevolence and Righteousness in Taiyuan. You didn’t know that?”

What the hell was this guy talking about?

After a brief silence, I spoke.

“You said you’d seen a lot of things, didn’t you?”

“What? Oh, that?”

“Yes, that.”

“Of course I read about that in books.”

“…Books?”

“Yes. There was a bookstore run by an old man in front of my house. For one nyang[801] in iron coins, you could read for half a shichen[802]. That’s where I nurtured my dreams.”

Mujin gazed out the window with a nostalgic look in his eyes.

“*The Shop Assistant Becomes a Sword God, You Must Hurt to Become a Martial Artist, The Son of Murim Walks Three and a Half Times Around the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes*[803], and so on… They were really interesting.”

“Oh, so you decided to become a martial artist after reading those books.”

“Of course. I even bought and kept a few of them when the bookstore went under. Would you like to borrow them?”

“No, I’m good. Anyway, Mujin.”

“Yes?”

“Do you really want to get beaten to death?”

I was an idiot for being impressed.

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[799] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[800] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[801] Nyang is a traditional unit of currency. Here it denotes an amount in iron coins, not modern won.
[802] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[803] “Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes” is a literary expression for the whole world.

This wuxia-novel[804] otaku[805] bastard was confusing fiction with reality. I grabbed Mujin by the lapels.

“Do you think novels and reality are the same? Huh? Didn’t any of the novels you read have someone getting beaten to death for running his mouth?”

“W-wait! Wait! I’ve never personally witnessed anything like that, but the Murim is more than capable of—”

“Right. Next otaku.[806]”

Smack!

Honghwa Inn stood in the heart of Taiyuan. Even in Taiyuan, known as Shanxi’s prime real estate, it was famous for its prime location.

It was only natural for the area in front of Honghwa Inn to be crowded with people, but today the crowd was unusually large.

“Oh dear, what’s all this?”

“There’s a carriage and soldiers… Hey, Mr. Yang, have you heard anything? Is a war breaking out?”

“I haven’t heard nothin’.”

Amid the murmuring, a luxurious, enormous carriage drawn by six fine horses came to a stop.

Then at least a hundred soldiers stood in neat ranks at the entrance to Honghwa Inn. An official dressed in his robes shouted loudly,

“Receive the royal command of His Highness Prince Shangshan!”

“Receive the royal command!”

The short phrase *royal command* carried tremendous weight. On top of that, the thunderous cry of a hundred elite soldiers caused hushed voices to spill out from every direction.

“Did you hear that?”

“Do you think my ears are decorations? I heard them say royal command.”

“Any idea what this is about?”

“I heard the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi is staying at Honghwa Inn. Isn’t it probably because of him? Everyone knows the young Prince likes martial arts.”

“I know that much, but I’m saying this because His Highness has never made such a commotion before.”

[804] Wuxia is a genre of Chinese martial-arts adventure fiction.
[805] Otaku is a Japanese term for a person with an intense interest in a hobby or fandom.
[806] Otaku is a Japanese term for a person with an intense interest in a hobby or fandom.

“Well, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi has become awfully famous lately. Not long ago, he even wiped out those Red Wind Band bastards in place of the government troops, so he’s certainly performed a great service.”

“Do you think His Highness plans to grant him an official post… Ah, they’re coming out! They’re coming!”

At someone’s shout, countless eyes turned toward the entrance of the inn.

The doors stood wide open. As the people summoned by the Prince appeared beneath the glaring sunlight, a wave of excitement spread through the onlookers.

“Oh! Is that the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“There’s more than one of them.”

“They’re wearing swords, so I suppose the others are young prodigies, too.”

“Then which one is the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“Can’t you tell at a glance? The tallest and most handsome one in the middle. That’s Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.”

“My, my. They’re all handsome men and beautiful women, aren’t they?”

As the people whispered, five figures emerged, each one worthy of being called a dragon or phoenix.

Among them, Jin Taekyung’s presence stood out like a crane among chickens. At the very moment admiring gazes poured toward him as he stood tall in the center —

“Ugh!”

Thud!

“…?”

“…?”

One of the young prodigies suddenly crumpled to the ground.

Not only the onlookers but even the soldiers standing at attention stared at the fallen prodigy as though they had no idea what was going on.

“Ahem. Ahem!”

At the official’s pointed cough, the fallen man’s face turned bright red.

The young prodigy who had fallen flat on his face got back up on legs trembling like a newborn calf. The official unfurled a red silk scroll.

“Ahem. Young prodigies of Murim, receive this royal command! I, the younger brother of the sacred Son of Heaven[807]…”

“Eek!”

Thud!

This time, the one who collapsed was a woman.

[807] Son of Heaven is a traditional title for the Emperor.

The unexpected accident made the official's breathing turn ragged for a moment. But he was the bearer of a royal command. He couldn't let something so trivial throw him off.

The official composed himself and took another breath.

"I-I…"

"Gasp!"

Thud!

"The command I bestow upon you…"

"Eek!"

Thud!

This time, even the official couldn't escape the disaster. Perhaps he had bitten his tongue, because a crunch came from his mouth, followed by blood streaming down his lips.

The crowd fell silent, though for a different reason than before.

As the official stood there in despair, one man strode confidently up to him and whispered,

"Do we really have to do this outside? Why don't we just do it inside?"

The official considered Taekyung's words for a moment before answering.

"Let'sh do that."

"…Just nod. You're getting blood on your clothes."

The official spoke with a grave expression.

"How on earth did this happen?"

Everyone was watching me for a response. In the end, I had no choice but to explain the situation as briefly and clearly as possible.

"The kids aren't feeling well."

"Not feeling well? What do you mean?"

"They're the fresh young pillars of Murim, aren't they? They trained so hard to become stronger that they wore themselves down. That's why they keep collapsing."

"Is that really what happened?"

"…"

"…"

It was quiet enough to hear a mouse breathe. I turned slightly and asked,

"He's asking whether that's true. Did you not hear him?"

The four young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi jolted as though they had seen a ghost.

"O-oh, no. We heard him. We were just thinking of an answer…"

"Th-that's right. I thought someone else would answer…"

"What is there to think about? Just tell him the truth. Isn't that right? Hahaha."

Of course, if they told the truth, they would get some private one-on-one time with me. The law was far away, and fists were close at hand.

If the four of them wanted to keep living peacefully in Shanxi Murim, they had no choice but to stay on the Jin Family of Taiyuan's good side. They forced the corners of their mouths upward.

"Well, that's what happened."

The official looked dubious as he asked another question.

"But why is one person missing? As I understand it, there should be six of you, including Young Hero Jin."

"Ah, you mean the Young Bureau Head of the Seongun Escort Bureau."

"That must be him. His name was…"

"Jintae. Woo Jintae."

"That's right. Why hasn't he come out?"

Because that one is in no condition to look human.

If I had known from the start that the Five Gates of Shanxi's young prodigies had been invited to this luncheon with me, I wouldn't have beaten him quite so badly.

Well, what's done is done.

All I could do was clean up the mess as best I could.

I shook my head with the most sympathetic expression I could manage.

"Last night, he was injured in a minor altercation and still hasn't regained consciousness."

"An altercation? Are you saying he got into a fistfight?"

"Something like that. In any case, his face is in such a state that he simply can't appear in front of people."

"Good heavens. What kind of fiend would do that to a guest invited by His Highness?"

"…"

This felt really strange. With the culprit standing right in front of him, the official muttered something about treason, then lamented.

"This is a serious matter. Whatever the reason, the fact remains that he can't attend the invitation. How furious will His Highness be when he learns of this?"

"Could I perhaps explain things to him properly?"

"Young Master, you don't understand. Once His Highness takes offense, no one can stop him. The surrounding area will be turned into a wasteland for the time being."

"Turned into a wasteland? What do you mean by that?"

“What else could I mean? First, they’ll arrest and severely punish the man who injured the Young Bureau Head of the Seongun Escort Bureau. Then, citing the terrible state of public order, dozens of officials will be forced to resign. I’ll probably be one of them.”

“…”

Why would they take it that far?

The official, who looked like he was about to be laid off in the prime of his life, added the finishing touch with a tragic expression.

“I have more than ten family members to feed… Sigh. I can only blame the heavens.”

He has a big family, too.

I was squirming in my seat and desperately racking my brain when—

“Yaaawn.”

A carefree yawn, completely at odds with the mood.

My eyes lit up when I saw someone coming downstairs with a long stretch.

“Hey, how about this?”

“Hm? What do you mean?”

“If we bring along an even more impressive young prodigy, there won’t be a problem. Right?”

“I can’t be certain, but that’s probably true. His Highness wouldn’t complain if you found someone even more outstanding.”

Perfect.

With a triumphant smile, I waved at Cheongpung.

He was a young prodigy who was no less than a Peak master.

“Have you ever seen a member of the imperial family?”

Chapter 138

The luxurious six-horse carriage raced onward without slowing.

Elite-looking soldiers cleared the road ahead, while the crowds swarming like ants parted to either side and watched the carriage fly past like the wind.

"So this is how Moses[808] felt."

Cheongpung reacted to my mutter.

"Moses? Who is that?"

"Someone."

"Oh, I see."

If it had been Hyuk Mujin, he would have complained for ages about me saying something weird, but Cheongpung was different.

He wore the excited expression of a child at an amusement park as he pressed and tapped every part of the carriage.

"This is my first time riding in a six-horse carriage!"

"…What about a four-horse carriage?"

"I've never ridden in one of those, either!"

"What about an ordinary carriage…?"

"I'd like to ride in one of those, too!"

"…"

If I put him on a subway, he would probably faint.

At this point, it would be much faster to count the things he had done than the things he hadn't.

I stared at the thoroughly excited Cheongpung.

What the hell is this guy?

Was he innocent or stupid?

Then again, he had said he had lived his entire life in the mountains. Maybe this was only natural.

At least he's easy to handle.

I still couldn't forget the expression he had just made. His eyes had lit up like high beams at the mere mention of the imperial family.

"Have you ever seen a member of the imperial family?"

"I want to! I'll see one! Please let me see one!"

What filled his eyes wasn't the sort of admiration ordinary commoners felt toward the imperial family. If I had to compare it to something, it was more like the excitement of going to see an elephant at the zoo.

He really is a strange one.

---

[808] In the biblical account, Moses parted the Red Sea to lead his people through it.

Apparently, I wasn't the only one who thought so.

The young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi, excluding the severely injured Woo Jintae, were staring at Cheongpung as if they were looking at something bizarre.

"There's something a little… off about him."

"Can we really go like this?"

"If he says something inappropriate in front of His Highness, we might get dragged into it, too."

"We'll be lucky if that's all he does. If he gets excited about seeing a member of the imperial family for the first time and pulls on Prince Shangshan's ear, we're finished. Completely finished."

…That was a surprisingly plausible prediction.

Hearing the young prodigies whispering, the official riding in the carriage with us leaned over anxiously and whispered.

"Um, Young Master Jin."

"Yes?"

"That man… Are you certain he's all right?"

"Trust me. He's a master I can vouch for."

"To hell with whether he's a master. I'm asking whether he's right in the head."

"Oh."

"Wouldn't it be better to bring along the martial artist who was with you instead?"

"Who? Ah, Hyuk Mujin?"

"I believe that was his name. I hear he's also quite skilled in martial arts."

If Mujin had heard that, he would have jumped for joy.

The problem was that he had a dark blue bruise on his face from getting beaten by me that morning, so there was no way he could come along.

Besides, Hyuk Mujin wouldn't be enough.

To avoid offending the young prince, I needed to bring a more impressive gift.

I firmly shook my head at the worried official.

"Don't worry. I'll take responsibility for keeping him under control."

Who was I? A direct descendant of the prestigious Jin Family of Taiyuan, a rising star, and Shanxi Murim's newest sensation.

My bold assurance brightened the official's expression a little.

"Then I'll trust Young Master Jin—"

Crack.

"…?"

"…?"

Wait a second. What was that sound?

As if on cue, we all turned our heads at the same time.

There was Cheongpung, clutching something in his hands.

“Huh? Why did this fall off?”

Cheongpung grinned foolishly, holding an exquisitely crafted golden dragon. After a long silence, the official looked at me.

“Young Master Jin.”

“Yes?”

“Are you certain he’s all right?”

After thinking it over, I opened my mouth.

“Probably.”

The space was so vast that it could have been called a castle rather than a residence. A man strode through it without hesitation.

Everyone who saw his tightly set lips and resolute gaze paid their respects.

“Greetings, Assistant Military Commissioner.”

He acknowledged them with a nod and quickened his pace.

After passing through a corridor lined with endless pillars, how long had he been walking? The man finally stopped when a massive iron gate engraved with a dragon appeared before him.

“Announce me.”

“Yes, sir.”

A commander of the guard saluted him and called out in a powerful voice.

“His Excellency Li Feng, Assistant Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province, entering!”

Before long, a voice answered from within.

“Let him enter.”

“…!”

The voice was neither as high and childish as a little boy’s nor as deep as a grown man’s.

The man—Li Feng—seemed to realize something. His eyebrows shot up just as the iron gate opened with a heavy groan.

Grrrnnng.

Beyond it lay an extravagantly decorated grand hall. Gold and silver treasures glittered in every direction, and a table large enough to seat dozens was laden with every delicacy from land and sea.

The sight would have left anyone else gaping. But Li Feng’s gaze remained fixed on a single point.

How is he here?

At the end of Li Feng's gaze, a man seated at the head of the table smiled faintly.

Wrapped in dazzling red silk, the man spoke in a coy, lilting voice.

"Well, well. If it isn't our Assistant Commissioner Li."

Our Assistant Commissioner Li?

Li Feng bit down on his lips and performed a military salute.

"…Greetings, Deputy Military Commissioner."

The Deputy Military Commissioner was a second-rank official, with only two such posts in each province.

Aside from the Military Commissioner, the supreme military commander, and Prince Shangshan, the City Lord, it was the highest position in the province. As deputy commander, he also wielded tremendous authority.

That was what the public knew. In truth, the man before him possessed even greater power.

That bastard deserves to be beaten to death.

A sycophant and corrupt official who used his glib tongue and petty tricks to blind the young prince's eyes and ears while lining his own pockets. That was Li Feng's assessment of him.

But even under Li Feng's hostile gaze, the man's smile never faltered.

"Assistant Commissioner Li, it's been a while. Isn't the atmosphere a little too tense? Did I perhaps do something to offend you?"

"…Of course not. I was merely surprised to find you in a place like this, Deputy Military Commissioner."

"A place like this?"

"It is a gathering of martial artists from the martial world. They are rather rough people, so I was concerned that you might be uncomfortable, Deputy Military Commissioner."

His words sounded considerate, but both men knew what he truly meant.

"Why would I? I like places like this. Besides, you've been awfully formal with my title. Just call me whatever you like. We're close enough, aren't we?"

"And what sort of relationship do we have?"

"The kind where we'd split even a single bean. True and loyal subjects who serve His Highness with all our hearts."

Split a bean? True and loyal subjects?

Li Feng asked bluntly, "Then may I call you Eunuch Hong?"

Eunuch Hong's smile stiffened for a moment.

With that single word, Li Feng had touched his sore spot.

"That's… a little too familiar, don't you think?"

"I only followed your instructions."

“Well, this is a surprise. I had no idea Assistant Commissioner Li considered me that close.”

“I’m overwhelmed that you finally understand how I feel.”

“Assistant Commissioner Li.”

“Did you call, Eunuch Hong? Or would you prefer that I go back to calling you Deputy Military Commissioner?”

A heavy silence settled over the hall.

It was a long while before Eunuch Hong spoke again.

“Our Assistant Commissioner Li has improved quite a bit, hasn’t he?”

“Have I?”

“Yes. Compared to a few years ago, you’ve made remarkable progress.”

“I’ve learned many things thanks to you.”

“I thought you were only good with a sword, but now I see you’re good with your tongue, too. I’ll have to look at you differently.”

“I’m still nowhere near as skilled as a certain someone.”

Their gazes collided in midair. Amid the taut silence, Eunuch Hong smiled gently.

“Well, we can talk about that later… May I ask you one thing?”

His opponent was no pushover, but he had taken a step back. If Li Feng kept biting at him, he would only put himself at a disadvantage. He silently nodded.

“Ask.”

“You said you used to belong to Huashan, didn’t you?”

Li Feng paused. Huashan was a place he both missed and remembered with pain.

It had been nearly ten years since he had left Mount Hua, but the memories of that time still remained deep in his body and heart.

“Yes. I was a lay disciple.”

“And Huashan is in Shaanxi?”

He and Eunuch Hong were what one might call political enemies. For that very reason, they knew one another inside and out.

Eunuch Hong was neither careless nor stupid enough to ask about such a basic fact without a reason.

If anything, he was a crafty bastard with a hundred snakes writhing inside him.

That only made Li Feng more puzzled.

“That’s right. But why are you suddenly asking?”

“I’ve come to know a few people recently, and I wondered if you might know them, too.”

“Are they martial artists?”

“Yes. From Shaanxi, no less.”

“Don’t tell me they’re from Huashan…?”

“Oh, come on. If they were, I would have told you already.”

Li Feng sighed in relief.

In the end, he had left of his own accord, but Huashan was still the sect he would be proud of for the rest of his life. It was a tremendous relief that Huashan had not become entangled with a sycophant like Eunuch Hong.

“There are more than one or two sects in Shaanxi. And I didn’t go outside while training at the main sect, so even if I heard their names, I might not recognize them.”

“Is that so? Then perhaps you would recognize them if you saw their faces?”

“…?”

At the sight of Li Feng’s expression, Eunuch Hong picked up the chopsticks lying on the table.

“You asked earlier why I was here, didn’t you?”

The beautifully crafted silver chopsticks tapped against a wine cup.

Ping.

The clear sound spread through the hall.

Eunuch Hong smiled with his eyes at the bewildered Li Feng.

“I invited a few acquaintances. Famous and powerful martial artists whom His Highness would enjoy meeting.”

At that moment, a powerful shout rang out from beyond the iron gate.

“The Three Hands of Zhongnan request an audience!”

“The Three Hands of Zhongnan… The Zhongnan Sect!”

Li Feng’s complexion changed drastically.

Huashan and the Zhongnan Sect had been bitter rivals fighting for supremacy in Shaanxi for a full hundred years.

Eunuch Hong’s intentions were every bit as clear as the smile on his face.

“They’re fellow Shaanxi men, so I thought I’d arrange a gathering. You don’t mind, do you?”

Just as Li Feng clenched his fists, the massive iron gate opened and three imposing men strode into the hall.

One of them had a familiar face.

“Well, well. If it isn’t Li Feng of Huashan?”

Li Feng shuddered. The moment he saw that man’s face, the humiliating memory from ten years ago came rushing back.

“How did you get here?”

The sharp-eyed man answered casually.

“How else? When the Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province invites

you, you have to come running even if it’s a thousand li[809] away. Isn’t that right?”

“You’re too kind. I’m the one grateful that you accepted the invitation.”

Li Feng ground his teeth. Gong Ilhyuk, the third of the Three Hands of Zhongnan, grinned at him.

“Anyway, you’ve done well for yourself. Assistant Military Commissioner, someone like you… Huashan must have spread around quite a few silver nyang[810] for you. Hmm?”

“How dare you insult Huashan?”

“Insult Huashan? You’re the one who insulted it. Ten years ago, who was it that fell to his knees after only a hundred or so exchanges with that magnificent Huashan martial arts?”

“You bastard!”

A thunderous shout burst from Li Feng’s mouth.

At the moment he glared at Gong Ilhyuk with eyes that seemed to pour out streams of flame, a third shout rang out from beyond the iron gate.

“The young prodigies of Shanxi Murim request an audience!”

[809] The Chinese li is a unit of distance equal to about 500 m (0.311 mi). A thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

[810] A silver nyang is a historical unit of silver currency.

Chapter 139

Less than a shichen[811] after the six-horse carriage carrying Jin Taekyung and his group departed, the streets of Taiyuan heated up once again.

This time, it was because of the fifty mounted soldiers surrounding the four-horse carriage, as well as the martial artists radiating sharp, piercing gazes.

“That’s…”

“It’s the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

“Woooooah!”

“First the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, and now the Jin Family of Taiyuan? What a feast for the eyes today!”

Inside the carriage, Jin Wikyung’s ears pricked up at the cheers pouring in from every direction.

“Mukyung, did you hear that just now?”

Jin Mukyung yawned and nodded.

“Yes. I heard it.”

“Wipeng, you too?”

Wipeng answered with an exasperated expression.

“You don’t care whether I heard it or not. Just say what you want to say.”

“Why do you always speak like that? Does it make you feel better?”

“Feel better? I’m about to give myself an ulcer as it is. So what did you want to say?”

“Those people just said Taekyung…”

“Wow. This is driving me insane.”

Jin Wikyung pretended not to hear Wipeng’s muttering and continued.

“It seems he’s on his way to attend a luncheon with the City Lord. He might even have arrived by now.”

“He probably has. It’s just a stone’s throw away.”

“You don’t think anything will happen, do you?”

“The Third Young Master isn’t some little child left by the water. He’s probably being treated to such a lavish meal that the table legs are breaking. Stop worrying.”

“I don’t know. He’s such a free-spirited child.”

Wipeng’s eyes went round as though he were asking what the hell that was supposed to mean.

“Free-spirited? Isn’t this more a case of him being reckless and out of control?”

“Ahem.”

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[811] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time period of approximately two hours.

"You could just say you're worried he'll cause trouble. Why dress it up like that…?"

"Shut your mouth."

"Yes. I won't say another word. If you're really that worried, ask the Second Young Master over there."

At Wipeng's indifferent reply, Jin Wikyung's gaze shifted slightly to the side.

In truth, Wipeng's advice was appropriate. Jin Mukyung was the only person among them who had ever met Shanxi's current City Lord, even once.

The problem is that he won't tell us anything else.

Jin Mukyung had dismissed his luncheon with the Shanxi City Lord with a single phrase—*It was fucking awful*—and had firmly kept his mouth shut ever since.

"Mukyung, by any chance…"

The answer came before he could finish.

"There shouldn't be any problems."

Jin Wikyung let out a sigh of relief at the decisive answer, but Jin Mukyung added one more thing.

"As long as he has a strong stomach."

"…A strong stomach? What are you talking about all of a sudden?"

This was a meal hosted by a member of the imperial family and the City Lord. Was he saying they might serve food crawling with maggots at such a grand banquet?

As Jin Wikyung stared at him in confusion, Jin Mukyung's face slowly twisted.

"There's someone there as revolting as a bug."

The Shanxi Provincial Office, where the City Lord resided, had long since ceased to resemble an ordinary estate.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect, which I had visited not long ago, were both enormous, but they looked laughably small compared to this place.

What am I supposed to call this? A fortress? Or a castle?

I had known for a long time that the continent operated on a massive scale, but this was beyond anything I had imagined.

Cheongpung, the other young prodigies, and I all gaped as we looked around. The official smiled faintly.

"What do you think?"

"It's big. Extremely big."

"It can easily accommodate several thousand people, so it has to be. If we had to defend it during wartime, we even have enough grain to last ten years."

The official pointed to several enormous warehouses one after another. He added that they were filled with food.

“All of those?”

“Of course.”

The official continued with a proud smile, like a resident of a Gangnam[812] apartment showing off his building.

“Provincial offices are generally built large and sturdy in preparation for wartime, but they aren’t normally this large.”

“Then…?”

“Have you already forgotten who lives here?”

“Oh.”

Right. He wasn’t merely the City Lord. He was a member of the imperial family. On top of that, he held an official royal title—he was a king in his own right.

“Then is this the royal palace?”

“In a manner of speaking.”

We continued moving, looking around like country bumpkins.

Everywhere we looked, servants and maidservants hurried about their business, while elite soldiers with razor-sharp discipline stood guard or sparred in the training grounds.

They’re pretty good.

The most surprising thing was the remarkably high quality of the soldiers.

Most of the soldiers standing guard were around Level 20, while the commanders wearing fairly impressive armor were comfortably above First Rate.

Well, it’s not as if there’s any reason soldiers shouldn’t learn martial arts when they’re readily available.

If anything, it would make the army stronger. It was something that ought to be encouraged.

I kept walking while stealing glances at the training grounds.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

“Thrust!”

“Argh!”

It was noon, with the sun already high overhead.

Hundreds of spearheads flashed in time with the drums, and the soldiers gathered and scattered in perfect unison, moving as one body.

Watching them train in formations, tactics, and battle strategies, one word suddenly came to mind.

Raid team.

[812] Gangnam is an affluent district of Seoul associated with expensive real estate.

Uniform weapons. Coordination drilled into them through systematic training. In a large-scale battle, that kind of teamwork would display terrifying power.

Their individual skills might be inferior to those of Murim martial artists.

A battle of dozens against dozens might be another story, but if hundreds fought hundreds, or thousands fought thousands, even an ordinary Peak master couldn't turn the tide by himself.

That was the terrifying strength of a trained group.

Make up for inferior quality with numbers and training. Is that it?

It was exactly what one would expect from a unified empire that had ruled a vast territory for centuries.

Wasn't that part of the reason those proud Murim martial artists acknowledged that they were subjects of a Great Nation?

And yet…

What the hell are they keeping all this for? To trade it in for candy?

There were already more than several hundred soldiers in sight. If even a portion of them had been sent to northern Shanxi, the Red Wind Band would have run so fast they'd have left their pants behind.

Fuck. Some of us nearly died going through all that trouble.

Seeing the true face of incompetent public authority suddenly plunged me into a spell of hollow enlightenment.

What good was owning the finest sword under heaven? If you didn't draw it from its scabbard, it was no different from a club.

Just as I was cursing them inwardly, the official spoke.

"Well, we're almost there."

He was right. A massive iron gate came into view at the end of a long corridor lined with dozens of pillars, drawing anxious sighs from both sides.

"Phew…"

"Whew. What do I do, Jeong? I'm so nervous."

"Don't worry. You have me."

"…What a fucking load of bullshit."

They say people destined to succeed will succeed, but I had no idea how those two had managed to hit it off in the middle of all this.

Maybe getting beaten together made them fall for each other?

What kind of country is this?

Unable to hide my discomfort as a two-star general of the Singles Brigade, I heard Cheongpung ask brightly as he walked along with a light step.

"Is the king in there?"

King.

At that single word, the young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi gaped, while the official leading us leaped as though he had been stung by a bee.

“A king? How impudent!”

“Huh? Isn’t he a king?”

“Of course he’s a king!”

“Then I was right, wasn’t I?”

“No, that’s not what I mean…!”

At this rate, one of two things would happen. The official would collapse from high blood pressure, or he would invoke treason and immediately summon the hundreds of soldiers training in the grounds.

I wanted neither, so I stepped in to mediate.

“First, calm down. And, Young Master Cheongpung.”

“Yes, Benefactor.”

“You can’t call him the king. You have to say ‘His Highness.‘ Right?”

I directed the last question at the official. He glared at Cheongpung and nodded furiously.

“Absolutely! You must!”

“Oh, really?”

“Phew. Yes.”

Cheongpung blinked his clear eyes.

“Why?”

“…Young Master Jin. Do we really have to take this bastard—I mean, this person—with us?”

“I don’t mind leaving him out. But are you sure you’ll be all right?”

The official fell silent for a moment.

If he took five people without Cheongpung, he would be reprimanded by his superiors and lose his job. But if Cheongpung let his tongue slip just once, he might lose his head.

A moment later, when he spoke again, his face looked ten years older.

“…Let’s just go.”

Cheongpung beamed.

“Thank you. If there’s time, I’ll put in a good word with the king—I mean, His Highness.”

“Please, just keep that gentleman’s mouth shut.”

While the official rattled off every precaution we needed to take, along with his earnest pleas, we finally reached the iron gate.

The gate was enormous and incredibly thick. Quiet voices drifted from behind it.

Assistant Military Commissioner, Huashan, insult?

Those fragments alone gave me no clue what they were discussing. Still…

The atmosphere doesn't seem very good.

I had a feeling this wasn't the best place for people to sit across from one another over a meal.

At that moment, a man standing at attention before the gate shouted loudly,

"The young prodigies of Shanxi Murim request an audience!"

Groooan.

The iron gate began to open at the same time.

The official gave me one final warning with a worried expression, stealing a sidelong glance at Cheongpung.

"Please just keep that man's mouth shut."

"…Ah. Yes."

He must have been seriously worried.

The moment we entered, it felt as though my eyes had brightened.

The lavishly decorated grand hall was filled with a long table like the ones I had only seen in movies set in magic schools, along with all kinds of food.

And the moment I saw the five people who had arrived ahead of us, only one thought crossed my mind.

We're screwed.

When it came to reading the room, I was second to none. After scraping by as an F-rank Hunter for so long, always watching everyone's mood, I could size up an atmosphere in 0.1 seconds.

Like right now.

What a wonderful atmosphere.

The air around the five people was pulled taut. I had sensed something was wrong from outside, but it was even worse than I had expected.

It was fortunate everyone was empty-handed given the occasion. If they'd had anything hanging from their waists, swords would already have been drawn.

"Well… Now that our guests have arrived, shall we end this reunion here?"

A man's delicate voice broke the tension.

Though was he really a man? He was slender enough to seem like a woman, with a pale face and lips as red as though they had been painted with dye.

SYSTEM

Level 22: Hong Jin

He smiled at me.

“What a strikingly handsome young man, just as one would expect of a young prodigy of the martial world. I heard a young hero from the Jin Family of Taiyuan would be joining us today. Might that be you…?”

Now was the time for introductions. I performed a fist-and-palm salute toward the five men.

“My name is Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

The unpleasant atmosphere immediately eased somewhat. Surprise painted over the traces of displeasure and ridicule lingering on the other four faces.

“If you’re Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan…”

A huge man dressed in black martial robes muttered.

From the moment I first saw him, he had radiated tough-guy energy. His name was Li Feng, and the number 68 hovered above his head.

Is he affiliated with the military?

I couldn’t judge everything from a first meeting, but that was the impression he gave. A proud and upright soldier. That was my first impression of him.

Li Feng, Li Feng… At Level 68, he’s probably Supreme First Rate?

Just as I was engraving his name and Level into my mind, the other three men reacted.

“Hm. That’s the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“He’s young. No, he’s a child.”

“He doesn’t particularly look as impressive as the rumors claim…”

Their curious gazes held surprise, a hint of jealousy, and a subtle sense of superiority.

In situations like this, there was usually no need to ask about the other person’s identity. They were the sort of people desperate to show off.

“Apologies for the late introduction, Junior.”

A sharp-eyed man grinned as he spoke to me. The other two stood with their arms folded, looking at me like I was a cute little chick.

This is weirdly irritating.

Who the hell were they to act like my Seniors right off the bat?

My question was answered soon enough.

“Oh, you don’t know yet, do you? We came from Shaanxi. The Zhongnan Sect of Shaanxi—have you heard of it?”

My mouth fell open before I knew it.

“Th-the Zhongnan Sect? *That* Zhongnan Sect?”

The three men’s faces blossomed with smiles.

“Haha! Look how surprised he is.”

“Exactly.”

“Perhaps you know our sect well?”
I shouted, suddenly brimming with excitement.
“I do! I know it very well! I had so much fun reading about it!”
“We’re glad to hear you know us… Wait. What do you mean, ‘reading about it’?”
“What else? Obviously, *The Reign…*”
I stopped halfway through my answer.
Ah. This wasn’t a novel.

Chapter 140

Gong Ilhyuk of the Three Hands of Zhongnan stared dubiously at the young man before him.

What's with this guy?

Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. He was the driving force behind a whirlwind that had quietly spread his name as far as Shaanxi in the span of only a few months.

Gong Ilhyuk mulled over what Jin Taekyung had said.

The Reign...[813] *What was it?*

It definitely seemed as though he had been about to say something before stopping himself.

Unlike his enthusiastic reaction when he first heard the name of the Zhongnan Sect, he now looked completely deflated and let out one deep sigh after another.

"Whew."

"...What's with the sighing?"

"It's nothing. Really."

"What do you mean, nothing? Go on. Finish what you were saying."

Gong Ilhyuk was beginning to feel irritated. What kind of sect was his? It was none other than the famous Zhongnan Sect.

It was one of the great pillars of Murim, a sect that had proudly earned its place among the Nine Sects and One Gang on the strength of centuries of history and deeply rooted martial traditions.

And yet...

Instead of being grateful that I acknowledged him, he sighs?

No matter how successful the Jin Family of Taiyuan had become, it was still merely a family from the frontier.

Compared to the Zhongnan Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, it was a firefly before the sun. In both background and personal fame, Jin Taekyung was an insignificant greenhorn far beneath him.

Arrogant bastard.

Gong Ilhyuk had spent his entire life taking pride in being a disciple of the Zhongnan Sect. Naturally, he was offended.

The other two members of the Three Hands of Zhongnan also regarded Jin Taekyung with displeasure.

"Ahem."

"Young friend, you have a habit of stopping halfway when you speak."

[813] "The Reign" is the opening fragment of a wuxia novel title Taekyung remembers.

As the atmosphere grew increasingly sour, Jin Taekyung waved a hand.

“No, it’s not like that. I just misunderstood something on my own.”

Gong Ilhyuk forced himself to speak magnanimously.

“What did you misunderstand? Tell me. I’ll answer everything.”

“It’s really nothing…”

“Ah, just tell me!”

“Huh? Why are you shouting?”

Gong Ilhyuk took a deep breath.

He was almost forty years old. Yet here he was, getting worked up over a brat barely twenty.

For some reason, just looking at that handsome face got under his skin.

“It’s not that… Whew. Anyway, tell me.”

“Hmm.”

Jin Taekyung finally spoke, as though he had no other choice.

“Then may I ask you one thing?”

“Anything.”

“What is the name of the current chairman of the Zhongnan Sect—or rather, the Sect Leader?”

“Hm? You mean the Sect Leader’s name?”

“Yes.”

What kind of question was that? Puzzled, Gong Ilhyuk answered.

“His family name is Gong. His given name is Iljung.”

“Ah. Yes.”

His indifferent response made it sound as though he had no idea who that was. Veins bulged on the foreheads of all three men.

“Have you never heard the Sect Leader’s name?”

Jin Taekyung scratched the back of his head.

“I might have. Or maybe not…”

“…Then what about his title, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord?”

“Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord Gong Iljung. Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord Gong Iljung… Hmm. Doesn’t ring a bell.”

It was beyond absurd.

The Sect Leaders and Family Heads of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were all renowned masters whose names resounded throughout the world. No martial artist could possibly be unaware of them.

Yet this fellow, a member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan rather than some half-baked martial artist, didn’t even know the Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect.

Worse, he casually repeated the man’s name as though they were friends.

Is this bastard mocking the Zhongnan Sect?

Gong Ilhyuk's head was still reeling from the shock when Jin Taekyung suddenly looked up at him.

"Oh? Come to think of it, your names are similar. Gong Iljung, Gong Ilhyuk."

At least he had some basic social awareness. Gong Ilhyuk's irritation eased slightly.

"He's an elder of my family."

"Oh, a family elder! Then are you two…?"

"He's my father's cousin."

"Your father's cousin!"

Seeing Jin Taekyung's eyes widen, Gong Ilhyuk squared his shoulders.

It wasn't just anyone. He was the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord. Being related to the Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect was an immense honor.

"Ahem. Don't spread it around too much. If this became widely known, people would start treating me differently."

In truth, no one wanted that fact widely known more than Gong Ilhyuk himself.

He had enjoyed all manner of benefits by invoking the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's name: superior martial arts, elixirs, and even the title of Three Hands of Zhongnan.

If he continued advancing at this rate, it was only a matter of time before he seized an important position within the Zhongnan Sect.

"You understand what I mean, don't you? If you truly must tell someone, limit it to a few close friends…"

Jin Taekyung waved him off.

"No way. I'd never tell anyone. It would obviously hurt Great Hero Gong's reputation. People would say, 'That bastard only made it this far because of his connections.' Oops. Sorry. Anyway, that kind of rumor would be troublesome, wouldn't it?"

Gong Ilhyuk gave a dry cough. Even he had to admit that the boy wasn't entirely wrong.

"Ahem. It's not as though it would hurt me that much. I only meant that there might be people who are curious about me…"

"Curious about you? I don't have a single friend, so there's no one I could tell."

"…Your eldest brother, the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family, might be curious. Or Heaven Shaking Sword."

"Oh, you don't know much about my family situation. My eldest brother is incredibly busy right now. My second brother isn't interested in much besides martial arts."

"…Is that so?"

"Yes."

There was nothing more Gong Ilhyuk could say.

As Gong Ilhyuk continued giving irritated coughs, Jin Taekyung smiled brightly.

“Besides, what would be the point of telling anyone? If he’s only your father’s cousin, you’re practically strangers. Here I thought you might be father and son or something.”

“…!”

Nothing in the world was more exhilarating than screwing someone over with a smile.

It was especially satisfying with arrogant bastards. Land the blow properly, and the rush was twice as sweet.

Ah, I could get addicted to this.

The Three Hands of Zhongnan, was it?

I hadn’t liked them from the start. Not the way they looked down on everyone, nor the way they strutted around because they belonged to some great sect.

So it really is different from the novel.

Back in high school, I’d dreamed of becoming a disciple of the Zhongnan Sect.

But as expected, reality was a cesspool.

I held back my laughter as I watched Gong Ilhyuk’s fists tremble.

Cute bastard. He’s so much fun to tease.

I wanted to keep going, but this was probably enough. If the Jin Family of Taiyuan was a local player, these guys were national-level. Nothing good would come of picking a fight with them.

Fortunately, a voice suddenly cut in and lightened the atmosphere.

“Aren’t you gentlemen monopolizing the conversation a little? The other guests must feel lonely. We haven’t even finished the introductions.”

The nasal, lilting voice gave me goose bumps once.

Then the pretty middle-aged man looked at me and winked, giving me goose bumps all over again.

“I haven’t introduced myself yet, have I? I’m Hong Jin, the Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province.”

“Deputy Military… what?”

“The Deputy Military Commissioner. Ah, you’re a martial artist, so I suppose this is your first time hearing of the office?”

“Yes.”

I'd heard of Comrade Chairman, but Comrade Deputy Military Commissioner[814] was a new one.

Hong Jin giggled as he looked at me blinking.

Good heavens. A middle-aged man was giggling.

"Why that expression? Did something bad happen?"

"…No. I'm just so happy."

"Happy? Ho ho ho, you're adorable. Don't you agree, Assistant Commissioner Li?"

He called me cute. Fuck, that bastard called me cute.

I barely managed to suppress my nausea as the man I had glimpsed earlier greeted me bluntly.

"I am Li Feng, Assistant Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province. I oversee the training of the soldiers attached to the Shanxi Provincial Office."

"And he's my direct subordinate. Isn't that right, Assistant Commissioner Li?"

Li Feng's thick eyebrow twitched.

We had known each other for less than five minutes, but I already knew one thing.

Li Feng hated Hong Jin.

That alone made him worthy of courtesy. I offered him a respectful fist-and-palm salute.

"My name is Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"I have heard much of your reputation. A great new star has risen in the martial world of Shanxi."

"A new star? You flatter me."

Li Feng shook his head gravely.

"No. Rumors are often exaggerated, but after seeing Young Hero Jin today, I can tell they were all true."

Kind words deserved kind words in return.

I brought up the soldiers I had seen on the way here.

"I was surprised by how skilled the soldiers were. I wondered who had trained them, but I suppose it was only natural that it would be you."

I gave him a firm thumbs-up, and a smile flickered across Li Feng's lips.

It had been so long since I'd had a normal, pleasant conversation that I was almost moved.

"If it would not be discourteous, could you introduce the others as well?"

"Of course. This is…"

"Greetings! To the respected Seniors of Murim and those who toil day and night for the sake of the nation…"

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[814] The Korean title *dojihwi dongji* ends in *dongji*, which sounds like the word for "comrade." Taekyung is joking about that similarity.

"…"

What was this, a job interview at a conglomerate?

The young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi had been waiting for their chance. They fell over one another to deliver extravagant introductions and lavish everyone with flattery.

That left only one person.

"All right. Junior, where are you from, and who are you?"

At Gong Ilhyuk's question, delivered with all the smugness of someone high on his seniority, Cheongpung blinked.

"Me?"

"Who else would I mean?"

"One, two, three, four… There are plenty of people besides me."

A vein bulged on Gong Ilhyuk's forehead.

"Not that! You're the only one who hasn't introduced himself!"

"Oh, I see. You called me Junior, so I didn't think you meant me."

"Good heavens! In Murim, we all share the same path! We're all seniors and juniors to one another. How do you not know that?"

If it had been me, I would have laid the sarcasm on thick.

But Cheongpung was Cheongpung.

He was in a different class from ordinary people.

"Wow, I've never been anyone's junior before! Please take good care of me!"

"…What kind of person is this?"

Sometimes, a pure child was much harder to deal with than an adult who had been properly tainted by the world.

Cheongpung spoke with a bright smile.

"My name is Cheongpung, and I live in Shanxi."

Gong Ilhyuk had been left speechless, but he finally came to his senses and stammered out a question.

"Ahem. Then you must also be one of the young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi."

"Huh? No."

"You're not?"

"No. I came from Henan."

"You just said you were from Shanxi."

"I live in Shanxi, so that makes me a Shanxi man. Hehe."

"You… Whew."

A furrow appeared in Gong Ilhyuk's forehead.

He clearly wanted to throw a punch right then and there, but the occasion forced him to hold himself back.

“Fine. Then which sect in Henan are you from? The Iron Blood Sect? The Five Tigers Sword Sect?”

“Where are those?”

“You’re from Henan, yet you’ve never heard of the Iron Blood Sect or the Five Tigers Sword Sect? How does that make any sense? What, are you from Shaolin Temple?”

“Oh, I only stayed in Henan for about two weeks before moving to Shanxi, so I don’t know much about it.”

“You said you were from Henan!”

“I did come from Henan, but before that, I was in Shaanxi…”

“You little bastard! Just say the whole world is your hometown!”

Gong Ilhyuk finally exploded. With a roar, he reached for Cheongpung’s collar—or tried to.

Grab.

His wrist was caught with absurd ease.

Gong Ilhyuk let out a hollow laugh.

“Well, look at you. You know at least one trick, huh?”

“Ah, I just reacted on instinct. I’m sorry, Senior.”

“On instinct? And you’re apologizing?”

Seeing Cheongpung apologize with a miserable expression, Gong Ilhyuk gave a short laugh.

“No. There’s no need to let go. No need to apologize, either.”

“Really?”

“Yes. But you’ll pay dearly for your reckless bravado.”

“What? What does that mean?”

“You’re about to find out.”

I stepped in at that exact moment.

I threw myself in front of Cheongpung, and Gong Ilhyuk regarded me coldly.

“Move aside, Junior.”

“Pardon me, Senior.”

“Pardon you… Should I take this to mean the Jin Family of Taiyuan intends to oppose the actions of our sect?”

I answered calmly.

“Not at all. I only want to stop this from becoming a bigger problem.”

“A problem? What problem?”

“His Highness will be arriving soon, won’t he? And there are plenty of eyes on us.”

“Plenty of eyes. Deputy Military Commissioner, what do you think?”

I could see Hong Jin smiling behind Gong Ilhyuk.

His lilting voice followed.

“Well, I don’t think it will be much of a problem.”

Li Feng immediately objected.

“This is the grand hall. We cannot tolerate even a minor disturbance.”

“Assistant Commissioner Li, I find the word ‘tolerate’ unpleasant. Anyone listening might think you were my superior.”

“Deputy Military Commissioner!”

“Why, Assistant Military Commissioner?”

No sooner had Hong Jin finished speaking than the other two members of the Three Hands of Zhongnan quietly stepped in front of Li Feng.

True to the Zhongnan Sect’s reputation, both were at least Supreme First Rate masters.

Li Feng bit down hard on his lip, then looked at me and muttered,

“I’m sorry.”

Gong Ilhyuk smiled triumphantly.

“Well? What will you do now?”

What else could I do?

I shrugged once and stepped back. Gong Ilhyuk’s smile deepened.

“A wise choice.”

“I only wanted to prevent the problem from getting bigger. You understand, right?”

“Of course. Everyone here will remember it clearly.”

“I hope so.”

Cheongpung stared blankly at me.

“Benefactor, did I do something wrong?”

Gong Ilhyuk answered before I could.

“What? Wrong?”

His murderous gaze swung toward Cheongpung.

“Are you insulting me and the Zhongnan Sect right now?”

“That’s not it. I was just…”

“Can’t you shut that mouth of yours?”

A complicated, subtle expression appeared on Cheongpung’s face.

Then he said the one thing more than enough to make Gong Ilhyuk lose his reason.

“Wow, no one’s ever sworn at me before. This is fascinating.”

“You goddamn bastard…!”

Whoosh!

A heavy sound split the air.

Gong Ilhyuk’s fist shot toward Cheongpung’s ribs at blinding speed.

Then—

Crack. Crunch.

“…!”

“…!”

Amid the stunned silence, one man’s mouth fell open in agony.

His fist had been crushed. Bone jutted through the torn flesh of his forearm, and Gong Ilhyuk, drenched in blood, asked in a trembling voice,

“Wh-what is this? What kind of fist technique…?”

If he hadn’t asked, I would have.

I had expected this result, but not to this extent.

With a single counter, Cheongpung had rendered Gong Ilhyuk, a master above Level 70, completely helpless.

And…

“That wasn’t a fist technique.”

At my mutter, Cheongpung answered with a face that looked ready to vomit.

“Benefactor is right. It wasn’t a fist technique. It was a palm technique called the Taeeul Miri Palm. But Senior, you’re bleeding too much. The smell of blood is making my stomach churn. Urk!”

What a lunatic.

I let out a hollow laugh as Cheongpung flung Gong Ilhyuk aside and began to dry-heave.

That was when—

“Ta-Taeeul Miri Palm!”

Li Feng asked with his eyes wide.

“Did you just say Taeeul Miri Palm? Are you certain?”

“Urk, yes. My grandfather taught me.”

“M-May I ask his name?”

“Urk, Mae Jonghak—bleeegh!”

Splash!

I was shocked that Cheongpung had vomited in the very place where the king was about to arrive, but Li Feng seemed unfazed.

He trembled as though he had been struck by lightning, then squeezed out a single word.

“The Sword Saint…!”

Chapter 141

I recalled something Jin Mukyung had told me a few days ago.

One God, Three Saints, Ten Kings.

Great martial artists who had already become legends.

Going by that order, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had to be one of the top five Supreme Peak masters in the world.

Now even the Sword Saint is showing up.

Jin Mukyung had told me that the Fire King earned his place among the Ten Kings by hunting down and killing a thousand members of the Demonic Cult over four days and nights.

If that was what it took to earn a place among the Ten Kings, just how formidable was the Sword Saint, whose name ranked ahead of his?

Why do nothing but monsters keep popping up?

I was dumbfounded, but then I looked at Cheongpung and found myself nodding.

Beans grow where beans are planted. A monster had raised a monster.

There's no way a gifted freak like that could appear out of nowhere.

Cheongpung was unquestionably a Peak master.

He was only twenty years old. If he had grown up under the guidance of a phenomenal master like the Sword Saint, it made perfect sense.

"Urk, bleeegh!"

…Actually, it was starting to make less sense. How had someone like that become a Peak master?

I asked Cheongpung, who was still retching, "Are you all right?"

"I'm all right, urk!"

"You're clearly not."

"More importantly, Senior looks badly hurt, bleegh!"

"Don't call me Senior. I'm fine. A little spit and this much will heal right up."

"Really?"

Of course not.

I patted Cheongpung on the back and glanced around. Everyone except Hong Jin was staring at us wide-eyed.

"S-Sword Saint Mae Jonghak? The Sword Saint I know?"

"That idiot is the Sword Saint's grandson?"

"What on earth is going on…?"

Gong Ilhyuk's reaction stood out most of all. Apparently forgetting his pain, he stared blankly at Cheongpung before suddenly shouting.

“Nonsense! The Sword Saint has been in seclusion for more than thirty years! How dare a piece of trash like you claim to be the Sword Saint’s heir?”

“Sorry to interrupt.”

I scratched my chin and continued.

“Why don’t you stop the bleeding first? You’re losing an awful lot of blood.”

“…”

Gong Ilhyuk’s face turned bright red. He had to be embarrassed. His arm had been shattered with a single blow, yet he was still calling someone else a piece of trash.

“Tch. If only I hadn’t let my guard down…”

“Then shall we arrange a rematch once you’ve recovered? I can lend you my family’s training ground.”

Even if they fought a hundred times, Gong Ilhyuk would lose all hundred. The gap between them was that obvious.

The proof was that the moment I offered to set it up, Gong Ilhyuk went silent as though he had swallowed honey.

“Stop the bleeding first. Stop the bleeding.”

“…You bastard.”

Gong Ilhyuk glared at me murderously.

It seemed he had finally realized that I disliked him, but I didn’t feel particularly threatened.

You should’ve stopped when I told you to.

If word of what happened today got out, they were the ones who would suffer. They had gotten entangled with the Sword Saint’s grandson, and even the Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect—Gong Ilhyuk’s father’s cousin—wouldn’t be happy about that.

Meanwhile, I wasn’t even directly involved, and I had gained an unexpected golden connection.

Listen here, I gave the Sword Saint’s grandson candied hawthorn skewers[815], took him to the hot springs, and did it all, okay? You bastard.

So this was how candied-hawthorn[816] stock went through the roof.

I was smiling inwardly when Gong Ilhyuk finished stopping the bleeding and sneered.

“Come to think of it, this is ridiculous. As far as I know, the Sword Saint had no children. How could he possibly have a grown grandson?”

Cheongpung, who had just stopped retching, tilted his head.

“That’s not true. I really am his grandson.”

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[815] Candied hawthorn skewers are fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

[816] Candied hawthorn skewers are fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

“The entire world knows that the Sword Saint devoted his entire life to martial arts! You’re obviously lying!”

“No, I’m really not.”

Cheongpung continued with a miserable expression.

“I really am my grandfather’s grandson. A crane brought me to him twenty years ago.”

“…?”

“…?”

What the fuck was that supposed to mean now?

As everyone’s attention turned toward him, Cheongpung looked back at me with a confused expression.

“Benefactor, am I mistaken?”

“What exactly do you know?”

“That cranes bring babies. Grandfather told me babies are chosen by Heaven, and when the time comes, a crane delivers them.”

“Who told you that?”

“My grandfather.”

“Oh.”

The story practically wrote itself. Their surnames were different, so the Sword Saint had obviously adopted him from somewhere…

Cheongpung had grown up alone with his grandfather in the mountains from an age he couldn’t even remember.

Whatever his grandfather told him, he must have simply accepted it.

“Cranes don’t bring babies? Then am I not my grandfather’s grandson?”

“Well, that’s…”

I continued with a heavy heart. Cheongpung was twenty years old. Now that he had come down from the mountains, it was time for him to learn about the world one thing at a time.

“There are three stages involved in having a child: ovulation, fertilization, and implantation. Try it.”

“With Benefactor?”

“Why would you do it with me? Are you insane? I said repeat the words out loud.”

“Yes. Ovulation, fertilization, implantation…”

However, my ambitious attempt at sex education had to end the moment it began.

“You bloody little bastards! How dare you behave like this in front of a great Senior of Murim!”

The owner of that growling voice was, of course, Gong Ilhyuk.

With help from the other two men officially known as the Three Hands of Zhongnan—but more accurately described as his lackeys—he had even gotten his arm splinted. Now he glared at us.

“A frontier bumpkin and a fool who throws his weight around just because he’s strong dare look down on a disciple of the great Zhongnan Sect?”

Cheongpung’s eyes went round.

“Am I the fool?”

“Probably.”

“Then Benefactor is the frontier bumpkin?”

“Thank you so much for clearing that up.”

I let out a deep sigh. The man was old enough to know better, yet he still couldn’t read the situation. Was his background as a member of the Zhongnan Sect, and his faith in his father’s cousin, simply too strong?

“Well, our Senior sure has a loose mouth.”

“What did you say?”

“Never mind me. What are you going to do if what this friend said is true?”

“If it were true, there’s no way Li Feng wouldn’t have recognized him.”

Li Feng? Why was Li Feng coming up now?

I looked at Li Feng, puzzled. He had gone rigid as though he had seen a ghost, but now he finally parted his lips.

“I am a lay disciple of Huashan. Until ten years ago, I was at the main sect.”

Gong Ilhyuk added with a mocking grin, “That fellow was quite prominent among the lay disciples. At least, until he lost to me during a friendly duel with our sect. Isn’t that right?”

“That’s right. I stayed at the Zhongnan Sect for two days for the duel, but I ate something bad and fell seriously ill.”

“That story again. Don’t you ever get tired of it?”

“Isn’t it a remarkable coincidence, no matter how often I think about it? Everyone scheduled to duel you, myself included, suffered the same fate.”

“…So you still can’t accept your defeat?”

“No. I accepted it long ago. In fact, thanks to you, I learned what Murim was really like. As tuition goes, it was a cheap lesson.”

Gong Ilhyuk’s eyebrow twitched at Li Feng’s calm tone.

“Enough pretending to be magnanimous. Answer me honestly. Have you ever seen that fool at Huashan?”

“Before that, let me ask you one thing. Do you still think I left Huashan because of you?”

“Of course. You ran away from Huashan less than two months after our duel. What excuse are you going to make now?”

“It’s true that I was discouraged for a while… but you’re wrong.”

Li Feng shook his head and continued slowly.

“It was about a month after that day. My Master suddenly said he had somewhere to go. When I followed him there, I found all the leaders of our sect gathered together, including the Sect Leader.”

“Did they hold a consolation banquet for a lay disciple? Huashan is more generous than I thought.”

“It is a generous sect. After all, they allowed a failure like me to accompany them on an important visit to see our Grandmaster.”

Gong Ilhyuk’s eyes narrowed.

“Your Grandmaster? Could it be…?”

“There is only one Grandmaster in our sect. Sword Saint Mae Jonghak. The one everyone knows.”

Gasps rose from several places around the hall. Meanwhile, growing unease spread across Gong Ilhyuk’s face.

“That’s impossible. I heard the Sword Saint hadn’t shown himself in a long time…”

“That’s true. But he was still on Huashan. His seclusion was simply so deep that we hadn’t been able to find him.”

“Th-Then what happened?”

“We combed through Huashan from top to bottom. Only after breaking through ten formations did we reach his residence. Can you guess what I saw there?”

Everyone present could guess. Li Feng’s gaze was fixed on Cheongpung’s face.

“A cute little boy. He was much smaller than the other children his age, but he was diligently swinging a sword… No one could laugh. Who could laugh after seeing a monster perform the Plum Blossom Sword Technique at the age of ten?”

“…!”

“…!”

Silent shock spread through the crowd. Gong Ilhyuk stammered.

“That—that’s impossible. As far as I know, one must be at least First Rate to perform the Plum Blossom Sword Technique…”

“Unimaginable things sometimes happen in Murim. Compared to that, pulling dirty tricks in a friendly duel is nothing.”

Li Feng gave a self-deprecating laugh.

“After more than a month of facing the wall in training[817], I came to a realization. I had no reason to remain there. That was why I left Huashan. What do you think? Isn’t it amusing?”

Li Feng’s story hit hard. Everyone, myself included, stared silently at Cheongpung.

[817] Wall-facing training is a meditative practice of sitting facing a wall to cultivate concentration.

Suddenly, I remembered the conversation I'd had with him at Honghwa Inn the night before.

"I was ten years old. One day, dozens of people came barging in and made a scene. I remember my grandfather shouting at them to get the hell out before he set fire to the mountain."

"Ah. So that's why he keeps changing where he lives…?"

"Yes. Fortunately, the mountain is so large that he's managed to avoid them for ten years."

Until then, I hadn't known that the people who had come to cause trouble ten years ago were the leaders of Huashan, or that the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was Cheongpung's grandfather.

And the part about them making a scene was only how it had appeared from young Cheongpung's perspective. The reality had probably been very different.

Who would cause trouble for the Sword Saint? That's a perfect way to get yourself killed.

The Sword Saint who had threatened to set fire to his own sect wasn't exactly ordinary, either.

In any case, on the day Huashan had nearly become a real volcano, Li Feng had met Cheongpung as a child and clearly despaired after witnessing his talent.

Fair enough. First Rate at the age of ten.

Countless people failed to reach First Rate even after turning twenty.

Two of the rising martial artists from the Five Gates of Shanxi present here still fell short of being called First Rate masters.

And yet Cheongpung had reached that realm at the age of ten.

Could Jin Mukyung have done the same?

The moment that question occurred to me, Gong Ilhyuk shouted as though having a fit.

"Proof! What proof is there that he's that child?"

The rising martial artists of the Five Gates of Shanxi who had been trying desperately to curry favor, Hong Jin, who had been watching with great interest, and even the other two members of the Three Hands of Zhongnan all frowned as though they had planned it together.

"There is no proof. All I have is my memory."

"Exactly. Mountains and rivers change in ten years. Should I really trust your paltry memory?"

"No. To be honest, I'm not certain either. I don't know how that child grew up."

Li Feng answered calmly, then suddenly drew his sword.

Shing.

He studied the blade as it radiated a cold chill, then asked Cheongpung, “Young Hero, how much do you know about Huashan’s martial arts?”

Cheongpung answered with a bewildered expression.

“Uh, I’m not from Huashan.”

“You’re not from Huashan…”

“No. My grandfather just taught me various things because he said they would be good to learn.”

“Then allow me to ask. Of the Six Harmonies Sword, Plum Blossom Sword Technique, Supreme Clarity Sword, Taeeul Miri Palm, Falling Flower Chasing Shadow Palm, and Scattering Flowers Shadowless Hand… how many do you know?”

“All of them.”

“Heh. All of them. Every one.”

Li Feng gave a hollow laugh and handed his sword to Cheongpung.

“Could you perform the Plum Blossom Sword Technique?”

“My grandfather told me not to show my martial arts to anyone.”

“One form—no, a single sword stroke will suffice.”

After hesitating, Cheongpung took hold of the hilt.

“Then I’ll show you briefly.”

The instant he finished speaking, something changed.

Sssssss.

Sword Energy? No.

From Cheongpung’s head to his toes, tangible strands of purple qi flowed from his entire body.

It was Extreme Yang internal energy so potent that merely being near it scorched the breath in one’s lungs.

“The Zaha Divine Technique[818]…!”

Li Feng let out a cry of delight.

At that moment—

Whoosh!

The tip of Cheongpung’s sword traced a beautiful arc.

Like plum blossoms falling at the end of the season, a single streak of Sword Energy cleaved the enormous table in half.

The food, the dishes, even the sturdy table.

“Ah…”

A gasp escaped me before I knew it.

[818] A Huashan internal-energy technique.

Breaking things was easy. But Cheongpung's Sword Energy was so sharp and clean that, if the table hadn't collapsed a moment later, no one would have noticed it had been cut.

Boom! Crash!

As the table split in two and collapsed, Li Feng clasped his fist and palm in an exceedingly respectful salute.

"Li Feng, lay disciple of Huashan, pays his respects to Martial Uncle Cheongpung."

Chapter 142

"Li Feng, lay disciple[819] of Huashan, pays his respects to Martial Uncle Cheongpung."

Zaha Divine Technique. Plum Blossom Sword Technique. And finally, the last word to come from Li Feng's mouth:

Martial Uncle.

Gong Ilhyuk's face darkened at this unbelievable turn of events.

Then is that bastard really…?

Even if Cheongpung wasn't the Sword Saint's biological grandson, one thing was certain.

The idiot bowing over and over with a bewildered look on his face had inherited everything from the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak.

"Th-this can't be. It's impossible. This makes no sense…"

As Gong Ilhyuk stammered in denial, a lilting voice reached his ears.

"Great Hero Gong."

"Ah, Deputy Military Commissioner."

Gong Ilhyuk's expression brightened when he spotted Hong Jin.

The Zhongnan Sect had been pursuing various ventures through its government connections, and Hong Jin was one of the powerful figures in Shanxi Province they had come to know in the process.

He was also the only person who could offer Gong Ilhyuk a lifeline in his current predicament.

"What happened?"

Hong Jin's gentle voice put Gong Ilhyuk at ease.

"I must have been mistaken for a moment."

"Mistaken? About what?"

"I merely thought he was some fraud going around trading on the Sword Saint's name…"

"Well, I know next to nothing about martial arts, but he didn't look like a fraud to me."

"There, there was only a slight misunderstanding."

"A misunderstanding…"

Hong Jin murmured the word quietly, then stared directly at Gong Ilhyuk.

"Great Hero Gong."

"Yes, Deputy Military Commissioner."

"Do you know why I invited you and the others from the Zhongnan Sect here?"

[819] A lay disciple belongs to a sect without being a monk or entering monastic life.

“Yes. Of course I do.”

There were two reasons.

First, to become acquainted with Prince Shangshan, the City Lord of Shanxi and a member of the imperial family, and receive his approval for their new business venture.

Second, to put Hong Jin’s political rival, Li Feng, firmly in his place.

“But as you know, I’ve been rather busy lately. I was so distracted that I forgot to tell His Highness that other guests would be coming.”

“I see.”

The nasal quality had vanished from Hong Jin’s voice, leaving it completely dry. Gong Ilhyuk asked anxiously,

“But why are you suddenly bringing that up…?”

“I’d like you to leave for today.”

“What?”

“Wouldn’t the presence of uninvited guests put His Highness in a bad mood?”

It was an unmistakable order to leave. And on top of that, Hong Jin had called them uninvited guests.

Gong Ilhyuk protested.

“Uninvited guests? Deputy Military Commissioner, what exactly do you mean?”

“Oh my, must I say it twice? I mean exactly what I said. I failed to tell His Highness you were coming.”

Hong Jin was originally a palace attendant. He had remained at Prince Shangshan’s side since the prince was an infant, and thanks to that, he had risen to the post of Deputy Military Commissioner, becoming the power behind the Shanxi Provincial Office and the second-ranking figure in the military.

The young prince favored him above all others. And yet he was sending guests away merely because he had failed to mention them in advance?

“I, I’m not sure I understand what you’re saying, Deputy Military Commissioner…”

Hong Jin smiled sweetly at the flustered Gong Ilhyuk.

“Great Hero Gong.”

“Yes?”

“I didn’t think you were like this, but you’re a little slow, aren’t you?”

“…What?”

“Or are you simply bad at taking a hint?”

The sudden verbal abuse plunged the hall into silence. Gong Ilhyuk and the other two members of the Three Hands of Zhongnan clenched their trembling fists.

“You go too far.”

“Oh my, if that’s how it felt, then you understood my intentions perfectly. I did go a little too far on purpose.”

"Deputy Military Commissioner!"

"Lower your voice. This is the grand hall."

"Why are you suddenly acting like this? Are you disappointed in me because of what just happened?"

"I said lower your voice. And I'm not disappointed in you, Great Hero Gong. We aren't friends. We're hardly close enough to expect anything from each other, much less be disappointed."

"That… have you forgotten your agreement with our Zhongnan Sect?"

"Agreement? Oh, the one about opening a route into Shanxi Province?"

Hong Jin gave a short laugh and continued.

"That's how business works. Until a deal is finalized, it can fall apart at any moment. Surely you didn't think a few words meant everything was settled when His Highness hasn't even given his approval yet?"

Gong Ilhyuk barely managed to suppress his rising anger.

He had already boasted to his sect as though the deal were complete.

If the venture succeeded, he would receive a commensurate reward. If it failed, however, he would not escape a reprimand. He had no choice but to coax the eunuch standing before him.

"If this venture succeeds, wouldn't it benefit you as well, Deputy Military Commissioner? The Zhongnan Sect never forgets gratitude or grudges."

Adding *grudges* to *gratitude* was a veiled threat—a warning that Hong Jin might make an enemy of one of the Nine Sects and One Gang.[820]

Hong Jin had served as a palace attendant since childhood and witnessed all manner of political intrigue. There was no chance he had missed the hidden meaning behind Gong Ilhyuk's words.

Tsk. This is why martial artists are the way they are.

Hong Jin clicked his tongue inwardly.

Every word and action was clumsy and blatant.

Compared to a half-polished man like Gong Ilhyuk, Li Feng—taciturn, stubborn, and every inch a martial artist—was a far more troublesome opponent.

He doesn't even realize who holds the upper hand right now.

If he had a goal he wanted to achieve, even crawling on the ground would hardly have been enough. And yet he had added a threat on top of everything else.

That settled Hong Jin's decision.

"Great Hero Gong, I'm such a delicate person. Words like that frighten me too much to keep working with you."

"Ah, if there was any room for misunderstanding…"

[820] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a grouping of major Murim factions.

Gong Ilhyuk was about to apologize as though he had no idea what Hong Jin meant when Jin Taekyung, who had been watching the two men with a bored expression, casually tossed out a remark.

“Room for misunderstanding, my ass. Not even a passing dog would believe that.”

“You, you…!”

“Hey, Seniors of the Zhongnan Sect. I don’t know what kind of incredible business you’re running, but couldn’t you discuss it somewhere else later? I’m already miserable enough about the table being overturned.”

Hong Jin let out a quiet laugh at the sight of Taekyung licking his lips while looking at the food scattered across the floor.

“Don’t worry. Once these gentlemen leave, I’ll have fresh food brought in. Isn’t that right?”

Now Hong Jin was practically shoving them out the door.

Gong Ilhyuk gritted his teeth.

“Deputy Military Commissioner, I admit my judgment is terrible. But please think carefully about what you stand to gain and lose from today’s events.”

“You seem to be mistaken. I reached this decision after thoroughly weighing the practical benefits.”

“What does that mean…?”

“We’ll continue with the project. We’ll build a dedicated trade route and trading post connecting Shaanxi and Shanxi, and we’ll expand the scale as well.”

“Then that’s all the more reason to join hands with our sect!”

Hong Jin’s eyes widened at the desperate shout.

“Is the Zhongnan Sect the only sect in Shaanxi? As far as I know, there’s a place far older than the Zhongnan Sect—and one with a much better reputation among the public.”

“…Are you talking about Huashan?”

Gong Ilhyuk’s face twisted.

Huashan and the Zhongnan Sect had been bitter rivals, constantly at odds, for the past several hundred years.

If this project went to Huashan instead of some other sect, Gong Ilhyuk knew he would face far more than a light reprimand.

“How could you do this to me?”

“Of course I can. There’s a better option right in front of me.”

“Our sect is by no means inferior to Huashan. In fact, I can proudly say that in this generation, we have surpassed them.”

“‘I can proudly say.‘ It’s good to see such loyalty to one’s sect. But from my perspective, wouldn’t the phrase ‘acknowledged by all’ sound better?”

Hong Jin continued without missing a beat.

“Great Hero Gong, let me ask you directly. Does the Zhongnan Sect have a master like the Sword Saint?”

“…That is…”

“Then does it have a young prodigy as outstanding as Cheongpung over there?”

“…”

None of the Three Hands of Zhongnan, Gong Ilhyuk included, could easily answer.

The Sword Saint?

The Zhongnan Sect’s Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, was occasionally compared to the Ten Kings, but that was as far as it went.

As for a monster like Cheongpung, none of them had ever heard of such a person, much less seen one. Gong Ilhyuk in particular flushed red, having attacked first only to be brought to his knees in a single exchange.

“B-but our sect has no fewer Peak masters than Huashan.”

“I’ve heard that the strength of a Murim sect doesn’t depend on how many masters it has, but on *what kind* of masters it possesses.”

Hong Jin’s remark struck the heart of the matter, leaving Gong Ilhyuk momentarily speechless.

But no matter what it took, he had to prevent Huashan from taking their place.

“Furthermore, every venture we’ve undertaken with the government has been completed successfully. Huashan, on the other hand, has no experience with this sort of project. They’re bound to be clumsy and make mistakes.”

“Oh my, is that so?”

Hong Jin smiled and turned toward someone.

“Assistant Commissioner Li, what do you think?”

Li Feng, who had watched everything in silence, answered.

“That is true. Huashan does tend to draw a firm line between the government and Murim.”

Hong Jin frowned, and color returned to Gong Ilhyuk’s face.

But Li Feng’s heavy voice continued.

“However, doesn’t everyone have a first time?”

“Li Feng, you bastard!”

Hong Jin burst out laughing.

“Our Assistant Commissioner Li has truly come a long way.”

“Thanks to you.”

The two men had exchanged almost exactly the same words only half an hour earlier, but the atmosphere was now the exact opposite.

They continued their conversation in a warm and friendly atmosphere.

“I’d like you to act as our intermediary, Assistant Commissioner Li. What do you think?”

“Of course. I’ll send a messenger pigeon to my Master. The Sect Leader will be pleased to hear this news as well.”

“Ah, and you should also tell him that we have an honored guest here.”

Li Feng followed Hong Jin’s meaningful glance and smiled faintly.

“That is news our Grandmaster will be pleased to hear.”

“It’s a good start.”

“I think so too.”

Completely excluded from the conversation, Gong Ilhyuk trembled from head to toe.

Things had already gone too far to turn back. He swept a gaze filled with fury and betrayal across the room.

“How dare you look down on the Great Zhongnan Sect.”

“Hey, there’s something I’ve been meaning to say.”

The voice belonged to Jin Taekyung, who had suddenly cut into the conversation. He gave a short laugh and continued.

“We’re not looking down on the Zhongnan Sect. We’re looking down on you. You might not know this, but I’m a huge fan of the Zhongnan Sect. *The Reign…*[821] Anyway, I faithfully kept up with it through volume thirty-four.”

“What kind of bullshit are you spouting? A family without even a proper pedigree like the Jin Family of Taiyuan has no place butting in!”

Taekyung put on a wounded expression and poked Cheongpung in the side.

“Young Master Cheongpung, that old man says our family doesn’t even have a family tree.”

“What? He said that to my Benefactor?”

“Yeah. I know he’s a Senior, but isn’t that going too far? I’m too scared of the Nine Sects and One Gang[822] to answer him myself, so could you say something for me?”

“M-me? I’m not very good at things like that.”

“Am I not your Benefactor? Was I only your Benefactor in name?”

“No, of course not.”

“Then say what I tell you.”

After Taekyung finished whispering something to him, Cheongpung hesitantly opened his mouth.

“G-get… get…”

“Young Master Cheongpung, louder! You can do it!”

Buoyed by Taekyung’s encouragement, Cheongpung squeezed his eyes shut and shouted,

“Get lost, you boomer bastards!”

---

[821] *The Reign…* is the opening fragment of a wuxia novel title.

[822] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a grouping of major Murim factions.

"…!"

"…!"

Boomer? They didn't know exactly what it meant, but that wasn't important. It had been followed by the word *bastards*.

"You goddamn…!"

All three men, Gong Ilhyuk included, glared with their eyes wide open.

Who were they?

They were disciples of the Zhongnan Sect's headquarters. They were accustomed to the admiring gazes of others, and this was a humiliation they could never wash away.

But…

Gong Ilhyuk ground his teeth. "Let's go!"

Swallowing his outrage, he turned away. Neither the opponent nor the place was suitable for repaying this humiliation.

I'll make them pay for this someday. I swear it!

Blood dripped from the fist he clenched so hard it seemed it would crush.

He stormed out of the grand hall, his footsteps heavy and violent.

Behind him came the voices of Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung.

"Wow, you're good at swearing. Was that your first time too?"

"Yes! I've never sworn before!"

"For a first attempt, you've got some real talent. You should learn a lot from me from now on. As you go through life, there are plenty of times you'll need to use them even if you don't want to."

"Yes!"

Chapter 143

After the humiliated Three Hands of Zhongnan stormed out, Hong Jin pulled a small bell from his robes and shook it.

“Well, now that the uninvited guests are gone, I suppose we should clean up.”

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Exactly three times. Before the sound had even faded, the iron doors opened and dozens of servants entered, bowing at the waist.

“Clean the grand hall and bring out a fresh meal.”

“We’ll carry out your orders.”

They bowed once more, then moved with perfect coordination.

Without batting an eye, they began clearing away the split table, the scattered food, and even Cheongpung’s vomit.

They’re professionals. Absolute professionals.

They’d put most cleaning companies to shame.

Unlike me, Cheongpung had been groaning with the look of someone who desperately needed the bathroom. He cautiously approached the servants.

“I-I’m sorry. Let me help.”

One of the servants shook his head.

“No, sir. This is our duty.”

“But I made the mess, so at least let me…”

No matter how sturdy the servants were, they were facing a Peak master. They had no choice but to follow Cheongpung’s wishes.

But the moment Cheongpung wrested the cleaning tools from them and began cleaning up the vomit, he froze.

“Urk, uweeek!”

“…”

Please just stay still. Stop making more work for them.

As Cheongpung emptied his stomach yet again, Hong Jin gave Li Feng a doubtful look.

“Assistant Commissioner Li, is that young man really Sword Saint Mae Jonghak’s Disciple?”

“Certainly.”

“Then why is he like that?”

“Ahem.”

Li Feng cleared his throat, his face reddening. To him, Cheongpung was both Sword Saint Mae Jonghak’s Disciple and an elder of his sect, but even he couldn’t deny that Cheongpung was a little strange.

"I suppose it's because he's spent his life completely removed from the secular world."

"No, but even so. Are you saying Great Hero Mae didn't teach him the basics?"

"Well… from what I've seen and heard, my Grandmaster is rather unusual himself."

Rather unusual.

It was a valiant attempt to put things politely, but what I heard was, *They're two of a kind.*

Hong Jin must have gotten a similar impression, because he fell silent for a moment.

"Are you sure we can entrust this matter to Huashan?"

"…Yes."

Li Feng's answer came half a beat late. Hong Jin shook his head in disbelief.

"We can discuss that later. Shall we get going?"

His words made me suspicious, so I asked,

"Where? His Highness hasn't even arrived yet."

"That's exactly who I'm going to fetch."

"What?"

"If we stay here, we'll be waiting until sunset. I have a rough idea where His Highness is."

I watched Hong Jin turn away with a wink.

He'd be a decent guy if he just stopped doing that.

I was grateful that he had taken our side, but that was that, and this was this.

My backside is precious.

Hong Jin and Li Feng walked side by side at the front.

As I followed them, I gradually began to understand what positions they held here and how much influence they wielded.

"Loyalty!"

People's emotions show in their eyes, their bearing, and their voices.

The soldiers snapped off energetic military salutes to Li Feng, and their boundless respect was plain to see.

Understandable.

Li Feng, a lay disciple of Huashan, was a Supreme First Rate master. Respecting strength was a male instinct, and even at a glance he radiated an unmistakably masculine presence. From what little I'd seen, he was steadfast and taciturn.

But he isn't completely inflexible, either.

The fact that he'd accepted Hong Jin's proposal proved as much. Their relationship had clearly been hostile, but Li Feng knew when to join hands and when to let go.

No one disliked a superior who was reasonably flexible.

Then what about Hong Jin?

I shifted my gaze to the side.

Not a single soldier showed Hong Jin any respect as he walked along, frivolously wiggling his backside. If anything, some of them even cast contemptuous looks his way.

However…

"I-I pay my respects to Deputy Military Commissioner Hong."

"Mm. Yes. Good work."

"Yes, sir!"

Several officials and servants we passed practically groveled before him.

Their trembling voices and cautious footsteps made their feelings obvious.

They were afraid.

Respect and fear.

They were opposing emotions, but they had one thing in common.

Both came from the art of handling people. Li Feng and Hong Jin each held the support of their subordinates through respect and fear.

So one controls the military while the other controls civil affairs?

Shanxi Province was called a frontier region, but its size couldn't be ignored.

It was a respectable autonomous territory with a vast area and a population of several million registered in its household records.

Where there was land, people gathered. Where people gathered, power and wealth flowed. Even within the Shanxi Provincial Office, a fierce, unseen struggle for power was underway.

From what I've heard, Hong Jin seems to have the upper hand. But that's none of my business.

I was too busy making a living to get involved in someone else's power struggle.

After walking for some time while lost in thought, we passed through nine gates and came upon a group of people.

"Deputy Military Commissioner, and Assistant Military Commissioner, have you arrived?"

The tenth gate was particularly large and tall. I couldn't tell whether it had truly been built that way or only seemed so because a hundred soldiers surrounded it without leaving so much as a crack.

Wow. Talk about tight security.

Would a Peak master, and one capable of using Sword Energy at that, be needed to try anything here? Every one of the guards was heavily armed with armor, spears, swords, bows, and more. Sharp eyes gleamed from beneath their helmets.

Cheongpung, who had spent the entire walk exclaiming at everything around us, lowered his voice and whispered to me.

“Wow. What do these people do?”

“I’m not sure. Perhaps they’re the royal guard protecting Prince Shangshan?”

“The royal guard? They’re amazing…”

Cheongpung murmured vacantly, then clenched his fists.

“Benefactor, I’ve made up my mind.”

“About what?”

Why do I get nervous every time he opens his mouth?

Of course, my premonition proved correct again.

“I want to join the royal guard too!”

“…I don’t think that’s such a good idea.”

The Sword Saint probably wouldn’t be pleased to hear that.

I rubbed my throbbing forehead.

“Um, shouldn’t you get your grandfather’s permission first?”

“It’s all right. Grandfather said life is short, so whenever I find something I want to do, I should try it.”

“And that something is joining the royal guard?”

“Yes.”

Cheongpung stared intently at the royal guards standing in perfect rows, his eyes shining.

More precisely, he was staring at their gleaming black armor.

No way. Is this bastard…?

“…It’s not because the armor looks cool, is it?”

“Gasp.”

That was it.

What kind of lunatic joined the royal guard because he wanted their merchandise?

Li Feng, who had overheard our conversation, approached with a face that looked ten years older.

“Martial Uncle Cheongpung, I may be nothing more than a lowly lay disciple, but you are Huashan’s direct Disciple, someone who will bear the future of the sect on your shoulders. To abandon the sect and devote yourself to the military… Please be careful with what you say and do…”

Cheongpung looked as though Li Feng had hit the bull’s-eye. He frantically waved his hands.

“N-No, that’s not it. Really.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes, yes!”

“Then I’ll take your word for it. I was considering bringing you a suit of armor on the way out, if you needed one, but…”

Cheongpung took the bait immediately.

“Thank you. I’ll accept it gratefully, Great Hero Li.”

“…”

“…”

Is this bastard serious?

Oblivious to the sudden chill in the air, Cheongpung grinned.

“Great Hero Li is a good person.”

“I’m not Great Hero Li. I’m your Martial Nephew, Martial Uncle Cheongpung.”

“Martial Uncle, Martial Nephew. Those words feel awkward… Can’t we just call each other whatever feels comfortable?”

“No. Our sect’s hierarchy is strict. Call me Martial Nephew from now on. Then I’ll give you the armor.”

“Hmm. Even so…”

Li Feng delivered his final blow to the hesitating Cheongpung.

“If you call me Martial Nephew from now on, I’ll give you the weapons used by the royal guard as well.”

“Gasp…!”

Game over.

Merchandise wasn’t complete without the full set. On the verge of obtaining the Royal Guard Armor Set, Cheongpung spread his arms, his face glowing with joy.

“Martial Nephew Li Feng!”

Li Feng answered awkwardly.

“M-Martial Uncle Cheongpung.”

“I like Martial Nephew Li Feng best in the whole world!”

“…Thank you, Martial Uncle.”

I felt sorry for the Sword Saint, who had spent twenty years raising that bastard as his grandson.

While even the royal guards were distracted by this unexpected farce, Hong Jin let out a deep sigh.

“What are you doing? Why haven’t you opened the gate?”

The young prince barely came up to my chest, if that. Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao, was much smaller than I had expected—and much stronger.

Ssshhk, ssshhk, ssshhk!

That was not a sound a mere ten-year-old child should have been able to make with a sword.

His sword paths were sharp, and his footwork technique carried him busily across the training ground.

Even I, who wasn't particularly well versed in sword techniques, could tell that his skill was more than enough to make me nod in approval.

So there was a reason he invited us.

When I first received Prince Shangshan's invitation, I'd had only one thought.

I'll go tell him a few heroic tales he wants to hear.

That was about it.

But this child was different. Instead of telling him stories about my exploits, I might have to teach him about martial arts.

"What do you think of His Highness?"

Hong Jin asked after dismissing all the attendants waiting outside the training ground with a single gesture.

Even then, the young prince was so absorbed in his martial arts that he didn't notice who had arrived or who had left.

"Exactly what sort of impression are you asking for?"

"Well, for starters, his martial arts?"

I answered honestly.

"He's better than I expected. No, he's outstanding. When did he begin learning?"

"He began showing an interest in martial arts three years ago."

"Three years…"

"Yes. Ever since the day he first held a sword, he hasn't missed a single day of martial arts training unless something unusual happened."

Li Feng smiled proudly and added, "He is unlike an ordinary child in many ways. His determination is remarkable. Much like yours, Young Hero Jin."

"Mine?"

"That's right. I heard Young Hero Jin worked himself to the bone from a young age. You've been making quite a name for yourself, just as one would expect from a master the Jin Family of Taiyuan secretly raised with such painstaking care."

"Uh… yes, I suppose."

That was a bogus rumor the Jin Family of Taiyuan had spread for public consumption.

In reality, I couldn't even remember what I'd been doing at the age of ten.

Probably going to elementary school or something.

Li Feng continued.

“You have no idea how delighted His Highness was when he heard the story of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. He must have been eagerly awaiting the chance to meet Young Hero Jin today.”

“…For someone who was looking forward to it, hasn’t he kept us waiting rather a long time?”

It felt like we’d been waiting for almost an hour. Was it because he was a prince? The little brat already had no basic manners.

Li Feng smiled faintly at my timid complaint.

“His Highness has a habit of immersing himself in martial arts whenever he is nervous. If he has offended you, please accept my apologies.”

There was no need to apologize over something like that. Just as I waved my hands dismissively, Hong Jin cupped both hands around his mouth and shouted,

“Your Hiiighness—!”

The small figure practicing his sword technique stopped dead at the shrill call. A moment later, he noticed us and crooked a finger.

“What is that supposed to be?”

“What do you think? His Highness is calling us.”

“What are we, neighborhood mutts?”

“Wow, I’ve never been a neighborhood mutt before!”

“…Please shut your mouth. No one here has ever been a neighborhood mutt.”

Suppressing my frustration, I walked toward the training ground.

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao. With every step, his face drew closer.

The rude ones always seem to be handsome.

Even at such a young age, his already fully formed features were sharp and distinct. His black eyes stared directly at me.

When I reached him, a voice that was still unmistakably childish drifted out.

“Do you know who I am?”

I had at least learned the basics of etiquette by now. I lowered myself onto one knee so that our eyes were level.

“Yes. His Highness, Prince Shangshan.”

“I do not yet know your name.”

“My name is Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

A faint trace of surprise appeared in his previously dignified eyes.

“T-The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung?”

“That’s right.”

I wondered how he would react.

The young prince remained silent for a long moment. Then he suddenly pulled something from his robes.

A wooden tablet about the size of an adult’s palm and a dagger.

“This…”

“…?”

He had handed them to me, so I accepted them. But what was I supposed to do with them?

As I stood there in bewilderment, Zhu Bao delivered a single dignified word.

“I would like your signature.”

“…”

Oh. He wants an autograph?

Chapter 144

He wanted my autograph. A king, no less.

What the hell is this?

I never saw this scenario coming.

As I stood there speechless with bewilderment, a pair of large eyes gazed steadily at me.

“Have I asked too much of you?”

“No, it’s not that… What are you planning to do with my signature?”

“Hmm. If you don’t want to, you don’t have to.”

Beneath the archaic speech straight out of a historical drama lurked an eagerness he couldn’t quite hide.

The tips of his feet scraped at the training ground floor like a puppy, and both his hands kept fidgeting restlessly. Those were proof enough.

The little guy is cute, though.

He was still a child. King or not, he couldn’t hide his age.

His expression was full of dignity, but his body was honest. A quiet laugh escaped me.

“Why are you laughing?”

“It’s nothing. So I just carve my name into this wooden tablet?”

The young king’s lips twitched.

“Preferably with your alias as well.”

Why was he answering so seriously over something like this? I held back my laughter and picked up the dagger.

Scritch, scritch, scritch.

Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. I rested the wooden tablet on my knee and carefully carved the seven characters into it.

That was when Zhu Bao suddenly asked, “Wouldn’t it be easier if you used Sword Energy?”

“It would.”

“Then why aren’t you using it?”

“It’s not that I won’t. I can’t.”

“You can’t use Sword Energy?”

“I mean exactly what I said. I’m not a Peak master yet, so I can’t use Sword Energy.”

“You’re… not a Peak master?”

I raised my head slightly. Zhu Bao was staring at me with a shocked expression.

“Aren’t you the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

"Yes, that's me."

"And yet you can't use Sword Energy? You're not a Peak master?"

"…That can happen."

"No, it can't!"

Wow. He almost sounded hurt.

I'd already been feeling inadequate with all the Sword Energy I'd been seeing lately. Now a little kid I had never seen before was twisting the knife.

Is being unable to use Sword Energy a crime?

I was hurt in my own way, and the young prince's fandom had taken a hit too.

I was wiping my nose in wounded frustration when he exclaimed, "How can you be so strong when you aren't even a Peak master?"

"What?"

"One Question, One Kill Jopil, Blade of Flowers Jin Baekyang, and most recently Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader. Weren't all the enemies you defeated powerful Peak masters?"

Jopil was the only one I could honestly claim to have defeated entirely through my own strength, but I nodded anyway.

"That's right."

"How was such a thing possible?"

"Well…"

The Inventory is fucking amazing. And nobody can withstand a group beating.

Whenever things look hopeless, try digging through your Inventory. You might find an elixir worth half a jiazi[823] or a weapon made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

…I can't exactly answer that way.

An image was something you built for yourself.

I opened my mouth with a gentle smile.

"Isn't it because I was stronger?"

"Wow!"

"There's a saying in Murim. The strong do not survive. Those who survive are strong."

"Wow!"

"I've fought three Peak masters so far. I was once even attacked by dozens of First Rate masters."

"How could that be!"

Zhu Bao clenched his tiny fists and gasped in admiration.

He gave such great reactions that it made me want to keep talking. I continued, recalling the moments of crisis I had fought my way through.

---

[823] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; half a jiazi is thirty years.

“But every time, I fought with everything I had and survived. Peak masters? Sword Energy? Those things aren’t important.”

“Sword Energy isn’t important? Do you mean that?”

“Of course.”

It’s fucking important.

Every bastard I met kept drawing out Sword Energy like endless strands of rice cake, and I was the only one who couldn’t use it.

Every fight left me wondering whether I had a human life or a fly’s.

Make sure you eat plenty of elixirs. Without Sword Energy, your body will suffer.

With outrageous disrespect, I placed a hand on the young king’s shoulder and whispered, “The desire to win. The unbreakable will to never give up until the very end. That is what made the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi who he is today.”

“An unbreakable will…!”

Zhu Bao’s small body trembled. Then, after letting out a heated sigh, he asked, “Can I become like you?”

“You can. From what I just saw of your training, you look like you’ll become a master in no time.”

“D-Do you really mean that?”

It’ll be tough without the System.

But you have to water a growing sprout.

I nodded at his enormous, sparkling eyes, carved a few more characters into the finished tablet, and handed it to him.

“Whenever things get hard, look at this and take heart.”

“What is this…?”

The young king examined the tablet and broke into a radiant smile.

“Thank you very much. I shall have this tablet enlarged and hang it on the signboard of the Shanxi Provincial Office.”

“…That?”

“Of course. Everyone who enters or leaves this place shall read your celebrated words.”

I looked at Zhu Bao, who was gazing fondly at the wooden tablet, and thought,

He’s going to hang that on the signboard of the Shanxi Provincial Office?

Dreams☆come true.[824]

—Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung—

…That?

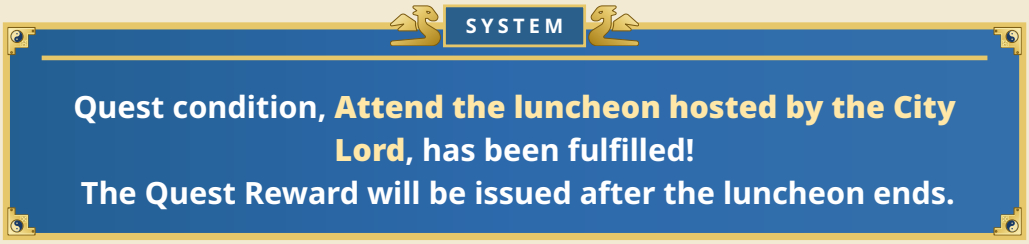
[824] “Dreams come true” is a slogan associated with South Korea’s run at the 2002 FIFA World Cup.

When we returned to the grand hall, it had been restored to pristine condition as though nothing had ever happened.

Once the servants filled the newly placed tables with delicacies from land and sea, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, seated at the seat of honor, spoke.

“I thank you all for willingly answering my summons. Now, please eat your fill.”

Ding.



The atmosphere that followed was warm and cheerful. With the young king, both host and master of the gathering, grinning from ear to ear, how could it not have been?

“I have heard that One Question, One Kill Jopil was an exceptionally vicious man. Could you tell me what he was like?”

“Oh, that bastard was absolutely brutal. Well, you see…”

“I’ve heard that Blade of Flowers Jin Baekyang was a Peak master whose name was known even in the Central Plains. How strong was he?”

“Fucking strong. The man was insane.”

“Young Hero Jin, His Highness is listening. Please mind your language.”

“Ah, sorry. Anyway, to tell you about what happened then…”

After telling stories for quite some time, I was exhausted. I tossed Cheongpung to Zhu Bao, who continued asking me questions, and quietly began edging away.

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, where are you going?”

“You know the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, right? This guy is his disciple.”

“The Sword Saint!”

“And he’s a Peak master, too. Ask him to teach you Sword Energy.”

Leaving Zhu Bao as delighted as a child meeting Santa Claus, I slipped off to one side.

I spotted the young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi silently cramming food into their mouths and two men engaged in a rather serious discussion.

Neither group was particularly inviting company.

I’ll just eat.

But before I could manage more than a few pieces of meat, a syrupy voice wormed into my ear.

“Young Hero Jiiin.”

“…What?”

Hearing that voice killed my appetite on the spot.

“What are you doing over there all by yourself? Come talk with us.”

“No, thank you. I’m hungry.”

“It’s about the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“I don’t get involved in family affairs. Talk to my eldest brother separately.”

“What a shame. Then I suppose we’ll have no choice but to entrust it to the Seongun Escort Bureau.”

The Seongun Escort Bureau? The name sounded familiar. Then I remembered—it belonged to the family of the guy I’d beaten black and blue at Honghwa Inn yesterday.

Hadn’t that guy been the Seongun Escort Bureau’s Young Bureau Head?

“Why the Seongun Escort Bureau?”

Hong Jin curled up the corners of his mouth.

“Oh, nothing. Please eat your meal. They say even a dog is left alone while it’s eating, so how could I bother the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“…”

“Hee-hee. I was joking. Don’t look so serious. Come over and sit down.”

Hong Jin pulled out the chair beside him. I sat down as though I had no choice.

Beside Li Feng, of course.

I’ll say it again: my ass is precious.

“Let’s hear what this is about. I’m not very knowledgeable in this area, so I may not be much help.”

Hong Jin had been pouting in feigned disappointment. Now he spoke.

“It doesn’t matter if Young Hero Jin doesn’t make a decision here. You only need to pass the matter along to the Lesser Family Head. Now, Assistant Commissioner Li?”

Li Feng took over.

“We would like to borrow the strength of the Jin Family of Taiyuan for this matter.”

“This matter being…?”

“I believe you’re aware of our plan to focus on connecting Shaanxi and Shanxi.”

“The thing you originally intended to do with the Zhongnan Sect?”

Hong Jin, who had been watching us, nodded.

“To be honest, the Zhongnan Sect isn’t a bad partner. It’s a massive sect belonging to the Nine Sects and One Gang, and its leadership, including the Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, has a practical nature. They’re different from the other, relatively closed-off Murim sects.”

“Then was there really any need to switch partners? If you hadn’t intended to work with Huashan from the start, leaving things as they were might have been better.”

"It was a decision I reached after giving it a great deal of thought. Although we overturned it today."

Hong Jin smiled faintly and continued.

"I'm not a martial artist, but I'm well aware of the Sword Saint's standing in Murim."

"…"

"But it has been more than thirty years since the Sword Saint disappeared. If we had known sooner that he had remained at Huashan and was raising successors, we wouldn't have chosen the Zhongnan Sect."

When he finished speaking, Hong Jin shot Li Feng a reproachful look.

Apparently, Li Feng had known about the Sword Saint and Cheongpung for the past ten years without breathing a word of it.

"Deputy Military Commissioner, I'll say it again: that was classified information belonging to our sect. There was simply no longer any reason to conceal it once Martial Uncle Cheongpung descended the mountain."

Li Feng replied calmly, then turned to me.

"I'll get straight to the point. We need an Escort Bureau capable of expanding into the Central Plains, starting with Shaanxi."

Ah, I had a rough idea of what was going on.

They were asking the Jin Family of Taiyuan to provide material or human resources.

"Are you planning to create an Escort Bureau?"

"Something similar. However, we would like to borrow the name of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. In return, we'll provide half the funding and every possible convenience."

They were openly offering to back us. Wouldn't it be better for them to create an Escort Bureau themselves at this point?

As I wondered about that, I suddenly remembered what Jin Mukyung had told me a few days ago.

He said that the current Emperor also assassinated his older brother, the Crown Prince, and ascended the throne. I'm sure of it.

It was only an unconfirmed rumor, but judging by how cautiously these two were acting, it didn't seem entirely baseless.

Could the Emperor's wariness have been the reason he sent his only younger brother to Shanxi Province, a region treated as a frontier?

Hmm. Something about this smells fishy too.

As I wondered whether I had gotten myself entangled in something dangerous, the two men spoke to me.

"We'll arrange a meeting regarding this matter in the coming days. Please put in a good word with the Lesser Family Head."

"Young Master Jin, you know this is a good offer, right?"

"I know. I do, but…"

Looked at one way, this was someone else's family feud. Ordinary brothers might fight over who got an extra ice cream, give each other bloody noses, and call it a day.

But this wasn't ice cream. It was the imperial throne.

A bloody nose wouldn't be the end of it.

"I'll make sure to pass it along to my eldest brother."

I deliberately kept my answer noncommittal. Jin Wikyung would be the one making the decision anyway, so there was no reason for me to worry about it—unless he asked for my opinion first.

"That will be enough. He won't simply dismiss something Young Master Jin tells him. We've heard plenty about how much the Lesser Family Head cherishes his younger brothers."

So the whole neighborhood knows.

I drained my cup of liquor with an embarrassed look, only to meet the eyes of the four of them sitting at the far end of a table some distance away. They all looked as though they were about to get indigestion.

Oh, right. I'd almost forgotten something.

"Excuse me. Comrade Chairman[825]—no, Deputy Military Commissioner."

"Yes?"

"That Escort Bureau business. Wouldn't it be enough to simply change the sign?"

Unlike the bewildered Li Feng, Hong Jin grinned.

"You have a place in mind?"

"The one the two of you were talking about earlier."

"The Seongun Escort Bureau? Don't take them too lightly. It's the foremost Escort Bureau in Shanxi, after all. They'll be difficult to swallow in one bite."

"That's why we have to chew thoroughly."

One look at their Young Bureau Head had told me exactly what we were dealing with. With Hong Jin and Li Feng backing the Jin Family of Taiyuan as it now stood, we could chew them up bones and all—and still digest them.

[825] "Comrade Chairman" imitates a North Korean style of addressing a leader.

Chapter 145

Hong Jin let out a quiet laugh and tipped back his cup.

“Our Young Master Jin is greedier than I thought.”

“I’m about as greedy as anyone else. And I have a favor to ask. Could you just call me Young Master Jin?”

“Oh my. Pretending you don’t like it when you do.”

“Fucking hell…”

“Hmm? What did you just say?”

“Ah, I said it’s nice. Like we’re family.”

“Family, huh? I like the sound of that. I’m already looking forward to meeting Lesser Family Head Jin.”

Right. No matter how much I ran my mouth here, the final decision would come down to Jin Wikyung and Hong Jin.

They were both practically professionals at this sort of thing. The amateur should know when to step aside.

“By the way, what do you have against the Seongun Escort Bureau?”

“I wouldn’t call it a grudge… I’m just giving someone I dislike an extra slap. The chance to pick up a few crumbs along the way doesn’t hurt either.”

“Ah. Does this have something to do with the Young Bureau Head of the Seongun Escort Bureau who was supposed to come?”

This man’s ability to read the room was anything but ordinary.

He’d already figured out the gist of it, so there was no point explaining every little detail. I shrugged.

“Something like that. How did you know?”

“Young Master Jin, I lived in the imperial palace for over twenty years.”

“Excuse me?”

“I survived by reading the room. Reading children’s expressions is easy enough.”

Hong Jin gestured with his chin toward the young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi.

At the far end of a table some distance away, they had been sneaking glances at us with frozen expressions. The moment they realized they’d been noticed, they flinched and shrank back.

“They’ve been like that since they first came in. Carefully watching Young Master Jin’s every move.”

“Really?”

“Yes. They looked so pitiful that even I felt sorry for them. What on earth did you do?”

“Something similar to what happened with the people who left earlier.”

“The Three Hands of Zhongnan? Tsk, tsk. They failed to recognize who they were dealing with, didn’t they?”

As expected, Hong Jin caught on at the slightest hint. He clicked his tongue in sympathy while Li Feng whipped his head around to stare at the young prodigies.

His gaze seemed to say that he intended to remember exactly who had provoked Martial Uncle Cheongpung.

“Gasp.”

“A-Assistant Military Commissioner! No, Great Hero Li! It’s not like that…”

Li Feng was not only a powerful figure in the Shanxi Province military but also a lay disciple of Huashan.

The government and Murim might supposedly stay out of each other’s affairs, but getting entangled with him in the wrong way would make the future of the Five Gates of Shanxi very unpleasant.

Leaving them as they hurriedly offered excuses, Li Feng asked me,

“Could you tell me in detail what happened?”

“It’s already over. The person involved even laid into them himself. What more is there to say?”

“Laid into them?”

“Ah, I mean he beat them up. They apologized first, of course.”

“Martial Uncle did it himself? Hmm.”

Strictly speaking, Cheongpung had only dealt with one of them, but he had beaten him all the same.

Li Feng looked at the young prodigies with a much gentler gaze.

“Do you understand what you did wrong?”

“Yes, sir!”

“We feel it in our bones!”

Their booming replies erupted immediately. Li Feng’s position was one thing, but now they also knew who Cheongpung was. No wonder they were sweating bullets.

Never mind that he was a Peak master. He was the Disciple of the Sword Saint and Huashan’s direct-line Disciple.

They’re completely fucked.

The Five Gates of Shanxi were ultimately just a collection of minor and mid-sized sects. If Huashan, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, got angry, even their extended families might get beaten with a bat.

No, they would be lucky if it ended there.

“The conversations and events that took place here today…”

Li Feng’s heavy voice had barely begun when the answers came flying out.

“We’ll keep silent!”

“We’ll take it to our graves!”

“I’ve already forgotten everything!”

“Where am I? Who am I?”

What a fucking performance.

As I watched an epidemic of amnesia break out before my eyes, I added one more thing.

“Is that enough?”

“Y-Yes?”

“What do you mean…?”

“What do you think I mean? If you want to be part of the family, put your spoon on the table too. You there. What does ‘family’ mean?”

The young prodigy I had pointed at stammered out an answer.

“People who eat together… Unless that’s wrong. Then I’m sorry.”

“That’s right. So, how do you become family?”

“Ah!”

The young prodigy cried out and slapped his forehead.

At least this one had some sense.

“Then I’ll arrange somewhere nice for our next meeting. How does Honghwaru sound?”

“…”

What a complete blockhead.

With heirs like these, I didn’t even need to look to know the state of the Five Gates of Shanxi. I heaved a deep sigh and spelled it out for him.

“Forget Honghwaru. I’m telling you to do whatever our side tells you to do. For example, anything involving the Seongun Escort Bureau. Understand?”

“Ohhh.”

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had certainly become the greatest power in Shanxi, but if the minor sects united and resisted, it would inevitably become a nuisance.

We belonged to the orthodox faction, after all. If we seized whatever we wanted and held people accountable like a band of mounted bandits, everyone would point fingers at us.

In Murim, wasn’t legitimacy every bit as important as martial arts?

But if there’s no one to point fingers, it won’t be a problem.

I slowly took in the four men and women before me—the heirs of the four sects among the Five Gates of Shanxi, excluding the Seongun Escort Bureau.

If they took the lead in supporting the Jin Family of Taiyuan, everything would become much easier.

“When you’re eating, pay close attention to where you sit. That way, you can at least get a bite or two.”

The Seongun Escort Bureau was supposedly one of the most prominent powers in the province, despite being located in a frontier region. It was more than enough of a feast to share around.

At my words, the quick-witted one's eyes quietly gleamed, while the clueless one cautiously opened his mouth.

"Even so, that might be a little…"

I cut the dim-looking bastard off without hesitation.

"What sect are you from?"

"M-Me?"

"Yes, you."

After a long hesitation, he finally coughed up the name Gopyeong Sect.

I vaguely recalled hearing it before, but it was some obscure sect I could barely remember. That was the extent of Gopyeong Sect's standing.

No, the same was true of every sect in the new Five Gates of Shanxi.

"Gopyeong Sect. Gopyeong Sect… It doesn't have a very pleasant ring to it. Should I recommend a new name?"

"Excuse me?"

I stared into the eyes of the bastard who still hadn't caught on.

"Starting next month, let's begin again under a new name. The Gopyeong Branch of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. How does that sound?"

"…!"

"…!"

"You don't seem to like it. I was only joking, you idiot."

Of course, I wasn't joking.

I patted the deathly pale Young Sect Leader of Gopyeong Sect on the shoulder and swept my gaze across the room.

"Is anyone here sworn brothers or sisters with Woo Jintae?"

"N-No, sir."

"Or maybe you've been close since childhood, knowing each other for more than ten years? Betrothed before birth? There are plenty of possibilities."

"Absolutely not! Absolutely not. We've only spent time together a few times."

"I-I only received a few bolts of silk and a little jewelry…"

"Then that settles it."

Clap!

The sharp crack of my hands coming together made all four of them flinch.

"Choose. Are you going to make enemies of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Huashan, and the government, or…"

I grinned and enunciated the final words clearly.

“Are you going to abandon someone you aren’t even close to and share the feast with us?”

Clap, clap, clap, clap.

This time, it wasn’t me. Hong Jin was cackling and applauding.

“Our Young Master Jin—I like you more and more every time I see you.”

“…”

Please refrain from making such dangerous remarks, brother.

“Are you leaving already?”

His tone was still arrogant, but his voice and eyes brimmed with regret.

The more I see this kid, the cuter he gets.

I reached out to pat my little fanboy—no, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao—on the head, only to lower my hand when I saw Li Feng’s expression.

Oh, right. He’s a king. And a member of the imperial family, at that.

“Ahem. I have urgent business to attend to.”

“Can you not put it off?”

“I’m sorry, but every moment counts.”

“I see…”

Looking at the dejected kid’s face made me feel a little guilty—like hell it did. I wanted to hurry back home to my family and get some proper rest.

Right on cue, Hong Jin cut in with his delicate voice.

“Your Highness, you have me, so please let Young Master Jin go now. All right?”

But Zhu Bao merely stared at me, his expression stubborn.

“Then when shall I be able to see you again?”

“Hmm, I don’t know. After a thousand nights?”

“A thousand nights!”

Zhu Bao cried out in shock.

That was approximately three years. For a child who was only ten years old, it must have seemed like an enormous amount of time.

“A-Are you truly that busy?”

“There are such things as adult matters, Your Highness.”

“Good heavens. Even my late father was never that busy…”

He looked utterly crushed. Zhu Bao’s head drooped, only to shoot back up at Li Feng’s next words.

“Your Highness, how about this?”

“What do you mean?”

“I hear the Jin Family of Taiyuan will be holding a grand banquet in fifteen days. Why not visit the Jin Family of Taiyuan in person?”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“Yes. All the renowned masters of Shanxi will be gathered there, so I’m sure you’ll be pleased.”

Zhu Bao’s eyes sparkled.

“Of course! Why didn’t I think of that?”

“Yes, Your Highness.”

“…”

What the hell were these two talking about?

They hadn’t even been invited, yet here they were letting their imaginations run wild. But if I told him not to come, it felt as though something would explode, so all I could do was nod.

“Great Hero Li is right. Come visit us then.”

“Would that really be all right?”

A little late to ask, wasn’t it?

I put on my best customer-service smile.

“Of course. My brothers will be happy to see you too.”

“I-Is that really true?”

“You know who my brothers are, don’t you? You’ve already met my second brother.”

“The Heaven Shaking Sword?”

A dark cloud suddenly fell over Zhu Bao’s bright, innocent face.

“Your second brother dislikes me. Three years ago, he only ate and left without saying a word. He was even rude.”

“He didn’t say a single word?”

“I do not wish to speak of that day anymore.”

Hong Jin whispered in a tiny voice,

“His Highness asked him for an autograph, but he flatly refused.”

Jin Mukyung had been invited three years ago, which meant…

Zhu Bao had been seven at the time.

Good grief. How could anyone flatly refuse a seven-year-old asking for an autograph—especially when that seven-year-old was a king?

That man really is something else.

In a way, it was very Jin Mukyung.

Recalling how his fanboy enthusiasm had been so brutally crushed, Zhu Bao silently fidgeted with his fingers.

Watching him, I felt a pang of sympathy.

“If you come this time, I’ll ask him to give you his autograph.”

“Really?”

“Pinky promise. Seal it.”

I hooked pinkies with the bewildered boy and even stamped our thumbs together.

“What is this?”

“It means I swear before the gods of heaven and earth. Something like that.”

“Oh!”

Everyone around us was making a fuss because he was royalty, because he was a king, and so on. But a child was still a child.

Everyone smiled fondly at the sight of Zhu Bao beside himself with delight.

“It’s been a long time since I’ve seen His Highness this happy.”

“I know. After dealing with this boring Assistant Military Commissioner every day, he’s smiling brightly for the first time in ages.”

“I’ve done nothing but my best.”

“Doing your best doesn’t always produce the best results. It happens.”

“Deputy Military Commissioner!”

“What is it, Assistant Military Commissioner?”

Li Feng and Hong Jin.

I could never tell whether the two of them got along or hated each other as they bickered back and forth.

Meanwhile, Cheongpung approached Zhu Bao with anticipation written all over his face.

“I-I could give you an autograph too?”

“…You’ve never given anyone an autograph before, have you?”

“Gasp. How did you know? I’ve left my hand mark as a caravan porter on the way here, but this is my first autograph.”

“Wouldn’t it be strange if I didn’t know?”

Just look at that expectant face. He was dying to give someone his first-ever autograph.

“C-Can’t I give him one?”

“Sure. Do whatever you want. His Highness will probably be pleased.”

But Zhu Bao’s reaction was unexpected.

“An autograph? From you?”

“Yes! I really want to give you my autograph!”

“No.”

“W-Why not? They say my grandfather is very famous. Haven’t you heard of the Sword Saint?”

“I know. Of course I know. But…”

Zhu Bao put on a deliberately stern expression and shook his head.

“You don’t have a martial title yet, do you?”

“Excuse me?”

“Come back after you’ve acquired a cool martial title. Then I shall certainly get your autograph.”

“…”

“…”

So this was something only named characters could do.

Chapter 146

Every meeting must eventually end in parting.

As the familiar six-horse carriage drew near, Zhu Bao held out something about the size of my palm.

“What is this?”

“My reward for today’s meeting.”

“Oh, you really didn’t have to…”

I accepted it and took a closer look. It was some kind of gold medallion.

Clouds and a dragon had been delicately engraved into its surface, which flashed brilliantly in the sunlight.

Ding.

SYSTEM

The Quest target is extremely pleased with today’s meeting!

As a Quest Reward, obtained Prince Shangshan’s Token!

“It is my token. If there is anything else you desire or a wish you would like granted, bring this token and come find me. I shall fulfill it to the best of my ability.”

“Oh.”

An exchange coupon.

Twenty coupons from a Chinese restaurant would get you a large serving of sweet-and-sour pork. Since this was an exchange coupon from Prince Shangshan, I might be able to trade it for all kinds of elixirs or treasures.

I do need a weapon, too.

Thanks to absorbing the Blazing Flame Divine Pill, I had more than enough internal energy.

It was just a shame that I didn’t have a decent spear. I’d been using and discarding other weapons like disposable chopsticks from the very beginning.

Should I just trade it in right now?

I considered it for a moment, then shook my head.

The greatest danger had already passed. With no urgent need, trading the prince’s token for a single weapon would be a waste.

“Thank you. I really wanted something like this.”

When I bowed deeply from the waist, Zhu Bao rose onto his tiptoes and gently ruffled my hair.

"I am happy that you like it."

"…"

This felt really strange. I'd let it slide because he was cute.

Meanwhile, the carriage that would take us home came to a stop. As I was about to climb aboard, Zhu Bao waved at me.

"Take care! Come again!"

Next time, you should come to me, you little punk.

There were only a little over two weeks left until New Year's Day. I would probably see the young prince again around then.

"Then I shall take my leave."

"I'll return, Your Highness."

The carriage was so large that even its entrance was wide. Hong Jin and I climbed aboard side by side.

"…Hm?"

Wait a minute. That had been so natural that I'd almost let it pass.

I stared at Hong Jin in disbelief.

"What is it?"

"Hm? Why?"

"This carriage is going to the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"I know. That's why I got on."

"What?"

"You know what they say—strike while the iron is hot. Shouldn't I take this opportunity to speak with the Lesser Family Head Jin?"

Hong Jin smiled pleasantly and snapped his fingers. An official came running over like the wind.

"Deputy Military Commissioner. Do you have an order for me?"

"We're visiting without an appointment, so we should at least bring plenty of gifts. Don't forget to send a messenger ahead to offer our respects."

"I shall carry out your orders!"

Li Feng also issued an order to one of his officers.

"He is an honored guest. Escort him to the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Yes, sir!"

At the two men's commands, nearly a hundred soldiers and a hastily assembled delegation began moving in perfect order.

Cheongpung, who had been about to climb aboard after us, gave a small round of applause at the sight.

"Wow."

Having obtained the royal guard gear set he had longed for so desperately, he decided to stay at the Jin Family of Taiyuan for the time being.

Li Feng dipped his head toward me.

“I entrust Martial Uncle[826] to you.”

“Of course.”

Even without hearing him say that, Cheongpung was someone I wanted to befriend first.

If I used him as a bridge to strengthen the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s relationship with Huashan, our family’s future would surely be bright.

Besides, he’s an interesting guy.

Cheongpung waved with a sunny smile.

“Martial Nephew[827] Li Feng, don’t worry about me! Interesting things keep happening whenever I’m with Young Master Jin!”

“Just in case, let me say this now. Don’t cause any trouble.”

“Yes!”

At least he was good at answering.

I turned toward the people who remained behind.

“What have you decided to do?”

The young prodigies of the Five Gates of Shanxi answered hesitantly.

“We plan to stay at Honghwa Inn until New Year’s Day.”

“There isn’t enough time to visit our families and return…”

“To be honest, we don’t even dare go back.”

“If I return now, my father might kill me.”

Their answers couldn’t have been gloomier.

Then again, rumors about what had happened the day before were probably already racing across the land like a winged horse, so their fear was understandable.

I clicked my tongue as I looked at them.

“Behave yourselves until New Year’s Day. I’ll smooth things over with the Sect Leaders later.”

“R-Really?”

“But in return, each of you needs to do your part. You know what I mean, right?”

“The Seongun Escort Bureau… Yes, sir. We understand.”

The tide could no longer be turned. By now, both these young men and the Sect Leaders of the Five Gates of Shanxi would know that.

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[826] *Martial Uncle* is a sect seniority title for someone of one’s teacher’s generation, not necessarily a relative.

[827] *Martial Nephew* is a sect seniority title for a disciple of a junior generation, not necessarily a relative.

From now on, all they could do was grow as large as possible under the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

"All right, then. Do your best, and I'll see you on New Year's Day."

"What?"

"Why? What is it?"

"W-we're going the same way."

"Where? To Honghwa Inn?"

"Yes."

I tossed one final remark at the bewildered young men.

"This is the express carriage to the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Bang!

The carriage began moving almost the instant the door slammed shut.

The inside had been spacious even with six people seated in it. Cheongpung, Hong Jin, and I each claimed several seats and leaned back against the soft cushions.

"I think I could live here."

Cheongpung continued with a blissful smile.

"When I lived with Grandfather, I slept on grass or rocks. I don't think I could live like that anymore."

He's a primitive man discovering civilization.

Hong Jin gave him a curious look.

"Then have you always lived on Huashan, Young Master?"

"Yes. Ever since I was very young. But apparently I wasn't born on Huashan. I asked Grandfather about it once, and he said I came to Huashan when I was three or four."

That figured. No matter how great a master the Sword Saint was, even he had his limits when it came to raising a child.

Reaching the Supreme Peak realm wouldn't make milk come out of a man's chest, after all.

"…"

Actually, a Supreme Peak master might be able to do it.

They were monsters who could use Sword Energy and Sword Force. Producing a little milk couldn't be beyond them.

I imagined a white-haired old man nursing a newborn baby.

"Ugh."

"Benefactor, are you all right?"

"Young Master Jin, are you all right?"

“I’m fine. I just felt a little nauseous.”

“Oh my, that won’t do. Here, lie down on my lap.”

“…”

Maybe I should just smash his knee.

When I hurled silent curses at him with my eyes, Hong Jin covered his mouth and laughed.

“Hoho. Young Master Jin really is so much fun to tease.”

If a beautiful woman had said that, I would have laughed along with her. But Hong Jin was unmistakably a man. No amount of white powder on his face or lipstick on his lips could change that fact.

He said he used to be a palace attendant.

Didn’t that make him a palace eunuch?

I’d once heard that not every palace eunuch had necessarily been castrated. But there was no way to tell whether Hong Jin was equipped or not.

“Young Master Jin.”

“Y-Yes?”

“What are you looking at?”

“Ah, I thought there was something stuck there.”

Damn it. He caught me.

He wasn’t a Murim martial artist, but his ability to read the situation was on the level of a Peak master. I quickly pulled my gaze away from Hong Jin’s lower body and changed the subject.

“By the way, how did Great Hero Li Feng end up joining the military?”

“Assistant Military Commissioner Li? He passed the military examination, of course. After that, it was smooth sailing all the way.”

“As expected of a Huashan lay disciple[828].”

“I can’t say that had no influence, but that wasn’t the only reason. Becoming a Third-Rank Assistant Military Commissioner in only ten years is extremely difficult.”

“Third-Rank means…?”

“What’s Third-Rank? Is it something you eat?”

I vaguely understood that it was a high position, but that was about it.

Seeing that Cheongpung and I had no idea what he was talking about, Hong Jin explained patiently.

“It’s a high office. There are only four such positions in each province, and Assistant Military Commissioner Li is among the top three in the military hierarchy.”

[828] A lay disciple trains under a martial sect without joining its resident religious community.

Hong Jin counted them off on his fingers.

“First is the Military Commissioner, the commander in chief. Then me, directly beneath him. And third is Assistant Military Commissioner Li. Of course, His Highness Prince Shangshan stands above us all.”

“The Military Commissioner?”

“He’ll be retiring soon. He was born the son of a Great General, accomplished a little, and has a tremendous fondness for bribes.”

A corrupt military official. The kind whose petty corruption had become a way of life.

With the commander in chief being that kind of man, it was easy to understand why security in Shanxi Province had been such a mess lately.

“The current Military Commissioner is incompetent. You only need to look at the mounted bandits roaming freely the moment the Mount Heng Sword Sect collapsed.”

“If he’s that incompetent, why not just…”

I swallowed the rest of the sentence before it left my mouth.

Who was I to meddle in someone else’s workplace? Especially when they were all high-ranking government officials.

Seeing my reaction, Hong Jin kindly added an explanation.

“The Military Commissioner is appointed directly by the Emperor. The same goes for dismissing him.”

“Oh.”

“Well, at least he has no ambitions beyond that. I like bribes too, so I’m hardly in a position to criticize him.”

What kind of person was this?

I’d seen plenty of politicians on television proclaiming their innocence against accusations of accepting bribes, but Hong Jin was the first person I’d met who openly admitted to liking them.

“Why? Did I look that upright?”

“No. You did look like someone who would enjoy bribes, but…”

“But you didn’t expect me to say it so openly?”

“Well, yes. Honestly, I’m a little flustered.”

“Young Master Jin. Do you know what?”

Hong Jin continued with a serious expression.

“I don’t have a thing.”

“What?”

“I’m a eunuch.”

“…”

What the hell was I supposed to say to that?

I'd suspected as much, but I hadn't expected him to drop a bomb like that out of nowhere.

Cheongpung, who had been looking out the window, abruptly joined in with a curious expression.

"What's a eunuch?"

"…Please, please shut your mouth."

He's saying he doesn't have his thing—his thing!

Every second dragged by. Sweating coldly, I forced myself to speak.

"I'm sorry to hear that."

"There's no need to be sorry. Some people live without one, and some live with one. Right?"

"Th—that's right."

His admirable attitude made me solemn for no reason.

Meanwhile, the mountain-dwelling primitive who didn't know what a eunuch was kept chattering without the slightest hint of tact.

"Benefactor, could you please tell me what a eunuch is?"

Even if I die, I'm not telling him. Never.

Even if I explained it, there was a 99.99 percent chance he would say something like, *Wow, I've never met anyone without a dick before!*

But Hong Jin remained composed.

"A eunuch doesn't have a dick."

"Wow, I've never met anyone without—"

"Oh, shut up already!"

Cheongpung sucked in a startled breath.

"B-Benefactor."

"Calm down, Young Master Jin. If he grew up in the mountains, it's understandable. And besides, it's not as if I've only been living as a eunuch for a day or two."

"Still, that was too harsh."

"Was I in the wrong? I'm truly sorry."

"It's fine. Chin up. Yours is still attached."

Decades of experience as a eunuch hadn't gone anywhere.

Hong Jin waved a hand as if to calm us down, then continued as though nothing important had happened.

"I've never regretted my decision. When your own family is starving to death, what wouldn't you do? Am I wrong?"

"Of course not."

"I—I would have done the same!"

Whatever Hong Jin said now, we had to agree with him. Cheongpung and I could only nod, feeling like condemned criminals.

“I’m not an upright man, but I’m not cowardly enough to betray a trust. If I were, I wouldn’t have continued serving His Highness all this time.”

Hong Jin gazed out the window with hazy eyes.

“Long ago, I served at the late Emperor’s side. He ordered me to assist His Highness Prince Shangshan.”

“The late Emperor?”

If the previous Emperor had entrusted Hong Jin with such a request, Hong Jin must have held a considerably high position among the palace attendants even back then.

Hong Jin nodded and continued.

“I came to the frontier in what was practically exile, but… I’m satisfied with things as they are now. Truly, this is enough.”

Despite his words, an unmistakable light shone in his eyes.

Ambition? Hope?

Before I could understand what that light meant, it disappeared, and the coachman’s quiet voice reached my ears.

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan is in sight.”

Chapter 147

Jin Wikyung let out a deep sigh.

“I have to start working the moment I return to the family.”

“Haven’t you been away for several days?”

“That was due to circumstances beyond my control!”

“Getting angry like this won’t make the work disappear.”

“Wipeng, save me. At this rate, I’m really going to die of overwork.”

Despite his desperate, pitiful plea, Wipeng answered coldly.

“Finish your work before you die. I’ll give you a grand funeral.”

“…You’re a demon. Are you even human?”

Jin Wikyung had returned to the Jin Family of Taiyuan half a day earlier only to find a mountain of work waiting for him.

Because he had been away for nearly ten days, hundreds of bamboo slips were scattered across not only the writing desk but also the floor.

“How am I supposed to do all this alone?”

“You can do it. You’ve done fine until now, so why are you making such a fuss?”

“Does our family really have so few people? No—are there really so few capable people in all of Shanxi Province?”

“Have you considered lowering your standards?”

“Are you saying this is my fault?”

“More than ten people have already come and gone. They all seemed like decent scholars to me, but you made the mistake of hiring only two.”

“Decent scholars? Please. Do you have no eye for people?”

They couldn’t accept just anyone simply because he had studied.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was, after all, a Murim sect. How much of the Four Books and Three Classics[829] someone had memorized, or what they had learned from which great scholar, wasn’t important.

Jin Wikyung wanted practical thinkers with flexible minds, not rigid scholars who spent their lives quoting Confucius and Mencius.

“Those two were the only useful ones among them.”

He still didn’t regret that choice. At his firm answer, Wipeng picked at his ear.

“Oh, really? Then where are those two now? What are they doing?”

“…Well, that’s…”

When Jin Wikyung was momentarily at a loss for words, Wipeng continued in his place.

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[829] The Four Books and Three Classics are canonical Confucian texts studied as part of a classical education.

“They worked four straight nights without sleep, then ran away.”

“R-ran away? Who says they ran away? One of them had a gravely ill mother…”

“I looked into him after he disappeared. His mother died ten years ago.”

“…Really?”

“The other one said he was going to the latrine, then slipped away and never came back. Am I wrong?”

“Ahem! Ahem!”

“My lord, you’ve trained in martial arts, so you can go without sleep for several nights and remain perfectly fine. Those men can’t. They’re ordinary commoners who have never read a single line of a cultivation technique formula in their lives.”

“Ah, I know that. That’s why I’m paying them generously.”

“Another fifteen days and that silver would have gone to their surviving families.”

“…”

“Anything else to say?”

“…No.”

“Then start working. From now on, if the scholars who come looking for work seem useful, hire them all.”

Jin Wikyung nodded gloomily and reached for a bamboo slip.

That was when one of the martial artists from the guard detail waiting outside the office cautiously entered and delivered an unexpected report.

“Who did you say?”

Wipeng answered Jin Wikyung’s question.

“A messenger sent by the Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province.”

“I heard that much. But the Deputy Military Commissioner is… the man said to be Prince Shangshan’s closest aide and the true power behind him?”

“Yes. There was plenty of talk about a mere palace attendant securing such a high-ranking military post.”

“Right. I remember.”

Jin Wikyung had heard the rumors about the palace attendant who sat at the top of the military hierarchy and single-handedly kept the young prince under his thumb.

“We’ve never even met. What could he want all of a sudden?”

“What do you think?”

“Could it be because of the Third Young Master?”

“Given the circumstances, that’s highly likely. Bring the messenger inside first.”

“Yes.”

“Ah, and call Mukyung too, just in case.”

“Understood.”

Not long after Wipeng nodded to one of his subordinates, a man entered the office.

His movements were precise and disciplined, and he wore light armor.

One glance was enough to tell that he belonged to the military. This was the messenger Hong Jin had sent.

“Are you the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

Jin Wikyung nodded.

“I am Jin Wikyung. Let’s skip the tedious formalities between us. What brings you here?”

“I have come to deliver a message from the Deputy Military Commissioner.”

“Does this concern my younger brother?”

“Yes. He is on his way here now, together with the Deputy Military Commissioner.”

“Together?”

“Yes. They should arrive in half a shichen.[830]”

Jin Wikyung silently stroked his chin as he listened.

Hong Jin was effectively the second-most powerful man in Shanxi Province. He wasn’t the sort of person who moved without a reason.

A letter alone would have been unexpected from a man with whom they had never had any connection. The fact that he was coming in person made it all the more bewildering.

“I don’t recall making an appointment.”

Wipeng added a remark with a face dripping with frost.

“No matter how high-ranking an official the Deputy Military Commissioner may be, this is a clear insult to our family. Are you aware of that?”

“Th-that…”

Beads of sweat formed on the messenger’s forehead.

He had received some minor training in military martial arts. Faced with the gaze of the Peak master known as the Ghost Sword, he felt his heart drop.

“What business brings him here?”

“I-I was only ordered to deliver his message…”

“He acts as though he owns the place.”

The messenger, who had become so nervous he could hardly sit still, was rescued by Jin Wikyung.

“Wipeng, that’s enough. So what exactly did the Deputy Military Commissioner say?”

“He told me to convey his apologies in advance for his sudden rudeness. And…”

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[830] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

The messenger took a small cylinder from inside his robes and handed it to Jin Wikyung. Inside the palm-sized cylinder was a rolled sheet of white paper.

“What is this?”

“I haven’t heard anything myself. He merely said that you would understand once it was delivered.”

“Hmm.”

Jin Wikyung deliberately furrowed his brow and unfolded the paper.

At that moment, the office door opened, and a second guest entered.

“Did you call for me?”

“…”

“Older brother?”

Jin Wikyung stared silently at the paper in his hand for a while before raising his head.

“You’re here.”

“Yes. I was training when I heard you were looking for me… Why did you call me?”

“We have an honored guest coming. We need to prepare to go out and greet him.”

“An honored guest?”

“My lord, what do you mean, an honored guest? Do we really need to go out and greet him?”

Wipeng frowned and objected.

“He’s coming without even giving us notice. What kind of honored guest is that? He’s an uninvited guest.”

He didn’t restrain himself even with the messenger standing right there. Considering the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s current standing in Shanxi, he wasn’t entirely wrong.

Jin Wikyung quietly handed him the paper.

“Look at this, then say that again.”

“What is it?”

“Seeing is believing.”

“You could simply tell me instead of making such a fuss…”

Wipeng’s voice gradually grew quieter before cutting off completely. His eyes trembled as they darted back and forth.

He stared intently at the paper. A moment later, his lips parted.

“An honored guest is coming.”

“Right?”

“Yes. Exactly.”

The two men turned toward Jin Mukyung, who was still standing there without a clue what was happening.

“Mukyung.”

“Second Young Master.”

“Yes?”

“You said you came straight from training, right?”

“You smell of sweat.”

“It’s only natural to sweat when you train.”

“Go wash.”

“Wash immediately.”

Baffled by their reaction, Jin Mukyung asked in frustration,

“Who on earth is coming to make you act like this?”

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng answered at the same time.

“A big spender.”

“And an extremely big one at that.”

Wipeng waved the paper in his hand. It was a thousand-nyang bank draft issued by the Golden Star Exchange, valid anywhere under heaven.

“This isn’t just a thousand nyang. It’s a thousand silver nyang.”

A thousand silver nyang was worth one hundred thousand nyang in iron coins. To the Jin Family of Taiyuan, which was already pouring money out in every direction, it was a fortune as welcome as rain during a drought.

For the first time in a long while, Jin Wikyung gave his second brother a stern look.

“Mukyung, let’s go wash up.”

“…”

The moment I got out of the carriage, a word slipped out on its own.

“Wow, fuck…”

There was no way I could stop myself from swearing. Atop the towering wall, a fluttering cloth banner displayed enormous letters that read:

The Day the Deputy Military Commissioner Came to the Jin Family of Taiyuan

This isn’t even Buddha’s Birthday. What the hell is this?

I was too embarrassed to lift my head when Hong Jin climbed down behind me and burst out laughing, clutching his stomach.

“Wow. This is even more than I expected.”

"Are you and my eldest brother old ball buddies[831] or something? How else did you get such an enthusiastic welcome…?"

"Young Master Jin, I don't have balls."

"Ah—oh. I'm sorry. I'm really sorry."

That was a tremendous blunder. Without a stick, there was no way any fertilized eggs would be left behind.

As I writhed under the weight of my guilt, Cheongpung approached and comforted me.

"Benefactor, my grandfather used to say that people who don't know how to read the room have no friends around them. But don't worry. I'll be your ball buddy.[832]"

"…"

I don't need one, you bastard.

As I struggled to swallow the curse, Hong Jin spoke.

"Young Master Jin, do you know what binds people together? Wealth. They say gold and silver can make even ghosts work for you. Living people should be even easier, don't you think?"

"So?"

"I told you I'd give him a present. It's basically a bribe."

Money can make even ghosts work for you.

I agreed with that to some extent, but I didn't like the fact that the person in question was Jin Wikyung.

I already thought of him as my older brother deep down. I didn't appreciate Hong Jin making him out to be some materialistic opportunist who could be bought with a bribe.

Perhaps that displeasure showed on my face, because Hong Jin smiled and said,

"Was that too harsh? But it's only natural. Who doesn't like wealth?"

"He's still my eldest brother. Don't think you've won over the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan with a measly few silver nyang."

"Young Master Jin…"

Hong Jin's eyes widened at my low voice.

"A few silver nyang? I gave him a thousand."

"A measly… How much?"

"A thousand silver nyang. One hundred thousand nyang in iron coins."

By now, I had a rough grasp of Murim prices and currency.

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[831] "Ball buddy" renders a Korean colloquial term for a close childhood friend. Its literal wording makes the exchange awkward for Taekyung.

[832] "Ball buddy" renders a Korean colloquial term for a close childhood friend. Its literal wording makes the exchange awkward for Taekyung.

The private suite at the Phoenix Inn, which could be considered a luxury hotel, cost fifty silver nyang per night. That was said to be close to twice the annual living expenses of a family of four commoners.

In modern money, that would be tens of millions of won.[833]

A thousand silver nyang was twenty times that. In other words, Hong Jin had casually tossed several hundred million won[834] at them in one go.

"That's… a lot, isn't it?"

"A lot, yes. I put in some effort this time."

"Still, that's far too much."

"It's for the sake of our future relationship. And right now, the Jin Family of Taiyuan is probably losing money faster than it's bringing money in. Winning a war and occupying the enemy's territory isn't the end of it."

"Ah, yes."

"The assistance you give at times like this feels much greater. I learned that after giving and receiving so many bribes myself. Ah, of course…"

Hong Jin continued with a wink.

"I also spent a little extra because I've taken quite a liking to you, Young Master Jin. You know how I feel, don't you?"

The moment he finished speaking, I felt a hard foreign object against my butt.

The repeated poking sensation jolted me wide awake.

No way. Is this bastard seriously…?

I swear, it was the most spine-chilling moment of my entire life.

Fine. You die, I die. Let's have another war!

I spun around at lightning speed.

What met my eyes was a silver lump about half the size of my palm. What did they call those again? A silver yuanbao?

"Here. Pocket money from me."

Oh, right. He's a eunuch.

I calmed my pounding heart and answered.

"Th-thank you."

"Sure. Go buy some candied hawthorn skewers.[835]"

"Benefactor, could you take me with you when you buy them?"

Cheongpung smacked his lips as he joined in.

Just then, a familiar voice rang out from behind us.

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[833] Tens of millions of won means roughly 10–99 million won, or about $7,100–$71,000 and €6,500–€64,000.

[834] Several hundred million won means roughly 200–900 million won, or about $140,000–$640,000 and €130,000–€580,000.

[835] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating fruit in hardened sugar.

"Heh heh. I'll tell the cooks separately, so ask for as many as you like. Isn't that right, Wipeng?"

"We'll build a mountain of candied hawthorn skewers.[836]"

"Who is that fellow? Candied hawthorn skewers?[837] He isn't even a child, so what's this about?"

I didn't need to look to know who it was.

I turned around with a happy smile, only to find a scene that left me speechless.

Flutter. Flutter.

Jin Wikyung was smiling broadly. So was Wipeng. Jin Mukyung's face was bright red.

In the hands of all three men, tiny scraps of cloth fluttered in the wind. I had no idea when they had made them.

> **Long live the Great Nation! Long live His Imperial Majesty the Emperor!**
> **His Highness Prince Shangshan, may you become a sage king!**

"…"

"…"

What had I said to Hong Jin earlier?

Had I told him not to think he'd won over the Lesser Family Head of the mighty Jin Family of Taiyuan with a measly few silver nyang?

Fuck, "won him over" my ass.

At this point, he was burned—burned to a crisp.

[836] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating fruit in hardened sugar.
[837] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating fruit in hardened sugar.

Chapter 148

In the atmosphere warmed by the enormous sum of a hundred thousand nyang[838], Jin Wikyung and Hong Jin exchanged greetings.

“I am Jin Wikyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. It is an immense pleasure to meet the Deputy Military Commissioner I’ve heard so much about.”

“To receive such a warm welcome from the Lesser Family Head of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan—I hardly know what to do with myself. Please, call me Comrade Hong from now on.”

“Even so, how could I address an official that casually?”

“Come now, you’re being too stiff. I said to call me casually.”

“Ha-ha. Then shall I, Comrade Hong?”

What was with the sudden communist atmosphere?

As I wondered whether I was in Pyongyang or the Murim, Jin Wikyung finished exchanging introductions and turned his gaze toward me.

“Hmm. Taekyung, you’re here?”

“Yes.”

His voice was heavier than usual, so I answered politely and read the room.

Apparently, he understood that acting as he normally did in front of outsiders would not only damage his personal dignity but also humiliate the entire family.

“So, did you greet His Highness properly?”

Properly? I didn’t just greet him. I even held a private autograph session.

Hong Jin smiled and patted my shoulder.

“His Highness was delighted. He’d always wanted to meet Young Master Jin here.”

“Oh, is that so?”

“Yes. He was so happy, he simply wouldn’t let him go.”

“Uhehehe. It seems our youngest—no. It seems His Highness has taken quite a liking to my younger brother.”

“I can see why. He’s handsome, tall, and well-built. He’s strong in martial arts and has such an easygoing personality. Who could dislike him?”

“Ahem. It feels rather awkward to say this myself, but Taekyung truly is an extraordinary talent. If he had been born into one of the Five Great Families instead of our family, no one would be surprised if he became the greatest under heaven.”

Jin Wikyung got so carried away that he forgot all about acting dignified. As he chattered excitedly, Hong Jin’s expression hardened.

“The greatest under heaven? Lesser Family Head Jin, that joke goes too far.”

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[838] A nyang was a traditional Korean unit of money, distinct from the modern won.

“Pardon? What do you mean?”

“You’re saying Young Master Jin has what it takes to become the greatest under heaven? Even if I have no connection to the Murim, surely you aren’t making light of me.”

“…Ahem.”

As the atmosphere instantly turned cold, Jin Wikyung gave an uncomfortable cough. Hong Jin immediately continued.

“Someone like Young Master Jin could become the greatest of all time.”

“…!”

“Allow me to congratulate you in advance, Lesser Family Head. For the greatest of all time to come from the Jin Family of Taiyuan—what a blessing for Shanxi Province.”

Jin Wikyung cried out, overcome with emotion.

“Comrade Hong!”

“Lesser Family Head Jin!”

“…”

They say Hong Jin lived in the imperial palace for twenty years. His skill with his tongue certainly wasn’t ordinary.

I clicked my tongue as I watched Jin Wikyung rejoice as though he had found his soulmate.

“This won’t do. There’s no point staying here. I’ve already arranged a place, so why don’t we have a drink?”

“What should I do? I’m not very good with alcohol.”

“Ah, what a shame.”

“The only time I can’t drink is when there’s none to be had.”

“Comrade Hong!”

“Lesser Family Head Jin!”

“…”

“…”

Look at how perfectly they clicked together.

When the two men disappeared, laughing loudly with their arms around each other’s shoulders, Wipeng stared at me with an utterly dumbfounded expression.

“Is that man really the Deputy Military Commissioner?”

“Unfortunately, yes.”

“I heard he was once a palace attendant, but I never imagined he would be so frivolous.”

Well, then what did that make Jin Wikyung, a martial artist who had played along with every bit of it?

Jin Mukyung, who had been wearing a sour expression for some time, finally spoke.

"That's just the kind of man he is. Last time, he subtly stroked my shoulder. I barely stopped myself from breaking his arm."

He tore the cloth in his hands to shreds and flung it to the ground. Looking much more relieved, he said,

"Then I have important business, so I'll be leaving."

"What business? Training again, I assume."

"Is anything more important to a martial artist than training?"

"…No."

That left me with nothing to say.

As I stood there at a loss, merely smacking my lips, a clear, ringing voice rang out.

"Wow, that's exactly what my grandfather always says."

Wipeng and Jin Mukyung's gazes pierced Cheongpung like awls.

To ordinary people, Cheongpung was merely a young man with a slightly unusual air about him. To masters, however, he was something else entirely.

When both men's eyebrows shot upward, Cheongpung turned to me with a flustered expression.

"Uh, Benefactor. Did I do something wrong?"

"Wrong? Of course not. They're just intrigued. Right, gentlemen?"

Neither man took his eyes off Cheongpung. They merely nodded.

An extraordinarily young Peak master. It was only natural that they would be curious about the identity of this Cheongpung who had suddenly appeared out of nowhere.

"While we're at it, why don't you introduce yourselves? This is Cheongpung."

Before I had even finished speaking, Cheongpung bowed deeply.

"Hello, I'm Cheongpung! I've only been in Shanxi for a few days. Before that, I was in Henan, and before that…"

Where did this guy crawl out of?

The question was written all over their faces.

Just as I expected. I explained Cheongpung's identity simply and clearly.

"He's the Sword Saint's disciple."

"…!"

"…!"

The name of Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was practically a cheat code among martial artists.

Both men gaped at Cheongpung, too stunned to speak. Cheongpung cautiously asked,

“Um, which of you is the Heaven Shaking Sword?”

Still reeling from the shock, Jin Mukyung stammered out a reply.

“I-I’m the Heaven Shaking Sword. But are you really the Sword Saint, Great Hero Mae Jonghak’s…?”

“Yes. He’s my grandfather.”

“Gasp!”

He looked several times more shocked than when he had seen the Flame Divine Palm martial arts manual.

A young man claiming to be the disciple—and grandson—of a Supreme Peak master who was known to have gone into seclusion decades ago had suddenly appeared before them. Their reaction was understandable.

“This can’t be…”

“The Sword Saint’s successor…”

Cheongpung looked back and forth between the two astonished men, then smiled brightly.

“I didn’t know either until I came down the mountain.”

“Y-Young Hero. Did Great Hero Mae also descend the mountain…?”

His voice was filled with expectation and excitement.

Both men were swordsmen who had trained with the sword their entire lives. Mae Jonghak had attained such heights in the Way of the Sword that he had earned the title Sword Saint. To them, he was practically a god.

But Cheongpung’s answer shattered their expectations.

“No. I snuck out alone. There were people I wanted to meet.”

“Ah…”

“How unfortunate…”

“But putting that aside…”

Cheongpung looked at the two crestfallen men before speaking again.

His gleaming eyes had been fixed on Jin Mukyung for some time now.

“Are you really Young Hero Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword? The one from the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?”

“That’s right. I am Jin Mukyung.”

“Wow, I finally found you!”

“…Hmm?”

“I’ve been searching everywhere for you. From Heaven’s Gate Temple in Henan all the way here.”

What? The person that guy had been looking for was Jin Mukyung?

Wipeng, as well as Jin Mukyung himself, asked with bewildered expressions,

“You were looking for me?”

"Yes. Since you were nearby, I thought you'd be a decent place to start."

"A first? What does that mean?"

"A dueling tour."

Cheongpung smiled softly. It was completely different from the bright, innocent smile I had seen from him until now.

"I decided it while coming down the mountain. I won't return until I've defeated all the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes."

"…!"

"My grandfather told me this: A martial artist has no need for conversation. We contend through martial arts alone."

Sssss.

At that moment, I felt a wave of heat. Violet light-flames had risen around Cheongpung's entire body, surging upward.

I had already seen this once before.

The Zaha Divine Technique.

The Extreme Yang qi burned the cold away. The earth melted, and the soil scorched. Cheongpung opened his mouth with all traces of his smile gone.

"Shall we move somewhere else?"

"Is there any need?"

Jin Mukyung continued.

"Draw your sword."

Jin Mukyung let out a long breath. His rapidly beating heart slowly began to settle. Breathing was important in battle. Only now was he finally ready to draw his sword.

As he placed a hand on the hilt, he thought of one man's name.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

Not once had he forgotten that name since the day he first held a sword.

A legendary swordsman said to have reached the ultimate realm of the sword—or perhaps a realm beyond it.

Everyone revered the Sword Saint, but Jin Mukyung was different.

Someday, I will defeat him.

If anyone had heard him say that, they would have snorted. They would have pointed at him and called him crazy.

No matter how much of a genius Jin Mukyung was, he could never reach the Sword Saint's name. Ever since Mae Jonghak had begun to be called the Sword Saint, no one had surpassed him.

Decades ago, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had already written a new chapter in the history of the orthodox Murim and become the protagonist of a legend.

It doesn't matter. This is my goal.

It was not reckless arrogance. It was a goal.

A goal he had etched into his bones and heart every day as he trained with his sword.

And at this very moment, someone who had inherited everything from Sword Saint Mae Jonghak stood before him.

"My grandfather used to tell me, 'Compared to the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, you are nothing. Don't become arrogant.'"

Cheongpung slowly stepped forward. A single blue-steel sword dangled from his waist, tied on haphazardly, and his footsteps were as light as though he had come out for a stroll.

But…

There are no openings.

He looked utterly careless, but Jin Mukyung had no idea when or how he could attack.

Jin Mukyung licked his parched lips.

"I've never even met him… He praised me too highly."

"No. Honestly, you surprised me a little. I mean that."

Jin Mukyung knew that Cheongpung meant every word. That only made him feel stranger.

Only a little?

It had been more than twenty years since he began training with the sword. Talent and effort had brought him this far.

People called him a genius, gave him the martial title Heaven Shaking Sword, and counted him among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

He had believed he had never once become drunk on such empty fame, but…

I still have a long way to go.

At some point, he must have grown accustomed to the gazes of people who looked up to him.

The wound Pung Yang had inflicted on him not long ago seemed to throb again.

"Do you know something?"

"What?"

"That you're strong."

"Until recently, I wasn't certain. But now I know."

"Because you met me?"

"Yes. Because I met you, Young Hero Jin. Now I know what the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes are capable of."

“Is that so?”

Jin Mukyung let out a quiet laugh.

What an interesting guy. He possessed martial arts that rivaled—or even surpassed—those of an Elder of the Nine Sects and One Gang, yet he remained untainted by the world. He was pure. Honest.

He was a martial artist, but he didn’t fit in the Murim.

He’s the exact opposite of someone I know.

One person suddenly came to mind.

A guy who seemed like he could somehow survive no matter where he was thrown in the Murim, and who fought in the least martial-artist-like way imaginable.

“How old are you?”

“I turned twenty this year.”

“The same age as him, too. Coincidence? Or fate?”

“What?”

Instead of answering, Jin Mukyung shook his head.

In truth, he already knew the outcome of this duel. The qi of the Zaha Divine Technique surging through Cheongpung’s entire body was that overwhelming.

His only regret was that he couldn’t display the full extent of his skill against an opponent of this caliber.

What would that troublemaker do in a situation like this?

Jin Mukyung glanced at his troublesome younger brother. With a grin like a little devil’s, Taekyung was mouthing something.

You. Are. Fucked.

What a goddamn bastard.

Laughing hollowly, Jin Mukyung placed a hand on his sword hilt. The internal energy boiling up from his dantian coursed through every part of his body.

Cheongpung looked at Jin Mukyung’s sword and spoke.

“My grandfather told me something else, too. A duel doesn’t need an opening stance or anything like that.”

“I agree.”

The next moment—

With a tremendous boom, violet light-flames and silver Sword Energy collided.

Chapter 149

Xi’an’s history ran deep. Until the dynasties changed, it had been called the center of all under heaven for hundreds of years.

Its enormous population, the abundant resources produced by its plains and mines, and the famous scenic and historic sites left behind by three unified dynasties swept away by the passage of time still drew countless visitors to Xi’an.

In one of Xi’an’s bustling inns, two Confucian scholars dressed in thick fur coats were among those visitors.

“Come on, hurry up. If we want to get back to the inn before sunset, we’re running out of time.”

Unlike his enthusiastic friend, the other scholar shook his head with a thoroughly fed-up expression.

“Again?”

“What do you mean, again?”

“Can’t we just rest for today? We’ve been walking around for days. My legs feel like they’re about to break.”

“Don’t be such a baby. We walked a thousand ri[839] to get here—how can we just turn around and go home? At our age, do you really think we’ll ever have another chance to visit Xi’an?”

“Good grief. I came to sightsee in Xi’an, and now it looks like I’m going to end up sightseeing Mount Beimang.[840] Leave me alone.”

“Come now. I don’t know about the other places, but we absolutely have to visit Western Peak. You’ll regret it until the day you die if you miss such a magnificent sight.”

“Western Peak…”

The five most renowned mountains under heaven were known as the Five Great Mountains.

Western Peak referred to Huashan, which lay near Xi’an.

“Imagine climbing Huashan and looking down upon all under heaven. Doesn’t your lofty spirit surge at the mere thought?”

“Well… I suppose it does.”

Unable to resist his friend’s fervent persuasion, the scholar reluctantly nodded.

He knew perfectly well that Huashan was as famous for its breathtaking scenery as it was for its rugged terrain.

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[839] A Korean ri is about 393 m (0.244 mi); a thousand ri is about 393 km (244 mi).

[840] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds and death.

“Do you think a famous mountain became famous for no reason? We need to soak up plenty of its spiritually efficacious energy this time if we want good news at the next civil service examination. How many times have you already failed?”

“Why are you bringing that up all of a sudden?”

“Don’t get angry. Anyway, we’ll go to Huashan, take in some lofty spirit and some spiritual energy. That’s all I mean.”

When the scholar still looked hesitant, his friend added coaxingly,

“I won’t ask you to visit anywhere else. We’ll just stop at Lotus Peak and come straight back down.”

At that, even the scholar who had been stubbornly resisting began to waver. Who knew? Perhaps he really would pass the civil service examination with flying colors next year.

But one rumor still bothered him.

“I heard Huashan is crawling with martial artists…”

“If you mean Huashan’s Daoists, there’s nothing to worry about. An acquaintance of mine went there years ago and said he didn’t have any trouble.”

“Ahem. Then shall we give it a try?”

The scholar made a show of giving in as he rose, but suddenly lost his balance and staggered. The strength drained completely from his legs, which had been trembling for some time.

He was about to crack the back of his head against one of the many table corners scattered around him.

“Huh? Wh-whoa!”

Just as he was about to fall with a short scream, a rough, sturdy hand braced the scholar’s back.

“Ugh. I barely survived that.”

After barely righting himself, the scholar sighed in relief and looked at the owner of the hand.

The young man looked to be around thirty. He wore a white robe and had an ordinary appearance, but he offered the scholar a gentle smile.

“Are you all right?”

“Th-thank you, Young Master.”

“It was nothing.”

Having narrowly escaped disaster, the scholar looked at the young man with curiosity.

He looks ordinary.

He was of middling height and had a slender build. Yet he had supported the scholar, who outweighed him by several dozen geun,[841] with one hand.

[841] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb).

Wondering whether he might be a martial artist, the scholar glanced at his waist. It was bare, so apparently not.

He's much stronger than he looks.

Regardless, the young man had saved his life. The sages of old had said that repaying kindness was a person's duty.

"Thank you again. Thanks to you, Young Master, I avoided a terrible mishap."

"I only did what anyone should have done. Please don't concern yourself with it."

"You helped me greatly. How could I leave it at a few words? Why don't you join us? The meal is on me."

His fellow scholar cut in with an incredulous look.

"What are you talking about? What about Huashan? What about Lotus Peak?"

"Didn't you just see me nearly go to the grave? This is a sign that I should rest at the inn. And since the Young Master here saved me, I ought to repay him. Isn't that right?"

The young man smiled and waved him off.

"I'm really fine. I'm waiting for my companions."

"Companions? I've been watching you, and you've been sitting here alone for more than a shichen.[842]"

"Ha-ha. It seems something came up and they're running late. I have no choice but to wait."

He had already been there for more than a shichen,[843] and he still intended to keep waiting? He was as good-natured on the inside as he looked.

Still, with the young man saying he had companions, the scholar could hardly insist that he join them. He smacked his lips regretfully.

"Then it can't be helped. May peace prevail throughout your household for as long as you live, and may you enjoy good health and a long life."

"Huashan! Lotus Peak!"

"I'm going, so shut that obnoxious trap of yours."

"I knew I could count on you."

"I might just throw you off the summit of Lotus Peak."

The scholar glared at his companion and was just about to take a step when—

Bang!

A deafening boom that made everyone's hair stand on end rang out. The inn's door was smashed apart, and a man and a woman appeared amid a thunderous shout.

"We're here!"

"Eunhyang's here too!"

Every patron in the inn stared at them with their mouths hanging open.

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[842] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[843] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

They were shocked by the man's enormous physique and the beautiful girl's appearance.

What kind of combination is that?

Good heavens. I've never seen anyone so huge in my life.

The inn fell silent. Only one person showed no surprise—the young man who had helped the scholar moments before.

"You're late."

The man, who stood several heads taller than everyone else, scratched his head vigorously.

"I'm sorry. We got caught up in a little dispute on the way."

"What happened that made you more than a shichen[844] late?"

"Well, the thing is…"

When the man began to mumble, the girl who had introduced herself as Eunhyang cut in with a broad grin.

"Big Brother, have you ever heard of the Black Serpent Sect?"

"The Black Serpent Sect? I can't say I have. Going by the name alone, they don't sound like they do much good."

"That's right. They're a dark-path gang that runs a gambling den just up ahead. Their boss took one look at Brother Chulwoo and asked if he wanted to work with them… Mmph! Mmph-mmph!"

"No, he didn't! I swear! I look so innocent!"

The man named Chulwoo covered Eunhyang's mouth and protested, but no one in the inn believed him.

Look at that face. With a face like that, he's already one of the dark-path figures.

Even if I were the Black Serpent Sect's boss, I'd have tried to recruit him.

He'd be their number-one pick. Number one.

Everyone only muttered those words inwardly because Chulwoo had widened his eyes and was glaring around the room. Faced with the gaze of an enraged beast, the people could only swallow nervously.

Of course, one person was an exception again.

"So, what happened?"

At the young man's question, Chulwoo answered at once.

"I just told them I wasn't interested and sent them away."

"Is that true?"

Chulwoo's gaze slid away.

"Y-yes, it's true."

"There's blood on your fist."

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[844] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

“Gasp! Really? I definitely wiped it off!”

“…”

“…”

“Mmph. Mmph!”

The young man let out a deep sigh.

“Let go of Eunhyang first.”

“…Yes, Senior Brother.”

“Mmph—phew!”

Eunhyang was finally released. She scrunched up her face and spat repeatedly.

“Ugh, salty. When did you last wash your hands, Brother?”

“Yesterday.”

“What? I could swear I’ve seen you visit the privy at least five times between yesterday and today. Then… Ahh!”

“It’s all right. I smell wonderful even if I only bathe once every fifteen days.”

“Are you insane? No wonder women hate you.”

“What did you say?”

As the two growled at each other, the young man rubbed the corners of his eyes wearily.

These two were notorious troublemakers even within their sect. He had known that something like this would happen eventually, but he hadn’t expected them to cause trouble before they had even left Xi’an.

I couldn’t refuse when it was the Sect Leader’s order.

What could he do? He could only consider it his karma.

Already half drained of energy, he spoke.

“Do you both want to go back? Should I tell the Sect Leader to put you through wall-facing meditation until you come to your senses?”

“Gasp! No, Senior Brother.”

“I’m fine too, Big Brother.”

The young man deliberately hardened his expression.

“Come now. I’m not Big Brother. I’m your Senior Brother.”

“Yes, Big Brother.”

“Eunhyang, you… Phew. Never mind.”

“Hehe.”

How powerful was a beauty’s smile?

When Eunhyang smiled sweetly, the chilly atmosphere in the inn warmed at once.

That was when the innkeeper, who had been watching them nervously, approached.

“Um, sirs…”

The young man recognized the innkeeper and spoke with an apologetic expression.

“Ah, I’m sorry for causing such a commotion. We’ll leave right away.”

“No, that’s not it…”

The innkeeper glanced at Chulwoo with terrified eyes before continuing with difficulty.

“Compensation, please.”

“Ah.”

Only then did the smashed door come into view.

As the young man sighed again, Chulwoo swiftly pulled a silver nyang from a heavy pouch.

“This should be enough.”

“Where did you get this silver nyang?”

Eunhyang answered with a bright smile.

“The Black Serpent Sect.”

Chulwoo cried out in horror.

“Hey!”

“What? I didn’t do anything wrong.”

“You took a jade hairpin, too!”

“Oops. How did you know?”

“…”

Apparently, smashing the Black Serpent Sect hadn’t been enough. They had stripped the place of its valuables as well. The young man’s forehead began to throb.

“Return it immediately.”

“Senior Brother, even if those men kept this wealth, they’d only use it for evil deeds.”

“That’s right. Since it’s already happened, we could eat something delicious while we travel to our destination…”

The young man cut them off in a stern voice.

“Since when was running a gambling den an evil deed? Or have you seen them commit any evil with your own eyes?”

“We don’t need to see it. It’s obvious. They’re dark-path figures.”

“How could this vast Murim contain only one color? And if the Black Serpent Sect were truly a group of villains, the main sect would have taken action long ago.”

“But…”

“Enough. We’re in a hurry, so we’ll leave the valuables here. Is that all right, Innkeeper?”

By now, everyone in the inn knew that these people were martial artists—and that they had made enemies of one of Xi'an's dark-path factions.

The innkeeper, who desperately wanted to avoid entanglement with martial artists, looked as though he had stepped in filth.

"G-Great Hero, forgive me, but this is more than an old man like me can handle."

Chulwoo, about to lose the fruits of his hard work, spoke gruffly.

"Don't worry. Nothing will happen."

"Nothing may happen right now, but once you leave, I'll be in serious trouble."

"Come now, I said that won't happen. Even after we leave, they won't be able to touch a hair on your head."

"No, that's not something you can say so easily…"

Is his brain made of muscle too? He's damn short-sighted.

The innkeeper couldn't bring himself to say that aloud and could only suffer in silence. At that moment, the young man smiled calmly.

"When they come, just tell them one thing along with this pouch."

"Great Heroes, I don't think you understand what I'm saying…"

The innkeeper's words were cut short by the young man's voice.

"Tell them that Baek Museong, a first-generation disciple of Huashan, apologizes for his junior disciples' mistake."

The inn fell silent.

The name *Huashan* was intimidating enough, but the young man's name also sounded familiar, as though they had heard it somewhere before.

"Baek Museong of Huashan?"

"Baek Museong… Baek Museong… Wait. Could it be?"

Xi'an was practically Huashan's front yard. It didn't take long for a few martial arts aficionados to realize the young man's identity.

"Baek Museong, Huashan's Lone Crane!"

The title had been given to him because of his lofty bearing, like that of a solitary crane.

Renowned as an outstanding prodigy from the moment he entered Huashan, he also held another title.

"If he's Huashan's Lone Crane, isn't he the first of the Three Plum Blossom Elites?"

The current Sect Leader of Huashan had three disciples, every one of whom had grown into an outstanding master.

Naturally, they had been appointed Plum Blossom Swordsmen—the pride of Huashan—and soon distinguished themselves.

"I heard one of them was a woman… Then are those two—?"

"Why even ask? Didn't you hear her call Huashan's Lone Crane her Senior Brother?"

“Good heavens. I never thought I’d live to see all of the Three Plum Blossom Elites in a place like this.”

Ignoring the exclamations erupting throughout the inn, Baek Museong spoke.

“Would it really be impossible?”

The innkeeper answered with a solemn expression.

“I’ll return this property to the Black Serpent Sect at the risk of my life. At your command!”

“…”

“Ah, that’s right.”

At Baek Museong’s mutter, his two junior disciples turned toward him.

“What is it, Senior Brother?”

“Did you leave something behind?”

Baek Museong shook his head.

“I forgot to tell him that Huashan has been sealed off.”

“Tell who?”

“I don’t know his name. That man is going to drag his aching legs all the way there for nothing.”

Eunhyang clicked her tongue sympathetically.

“What a shame. He won’t have a chance for the next few months.”

“Indeed.”

They recalled the incident that had thrown all of Huashan into an uproar several days earlier.

While the Sect Leader—in other words, their Master—was asleep, an intruder had entered and left without anyone noticing.

The intruder had committed the audacious act of leaving a dagger and a handwritten letter beside the Sect Leader’s head.

> “I’m going out to get some air. Don’t slack off just because you’ve become Sect Leader. Train your martial arts when you should be sleeping.”

Under ordinary circumstances, they would have immediately cast a dragnet across the entire mountain. But if the intruder’s identity was Sword Saint Mae Jonghak, the matter was different.

The Sect Leader had immediately sealed Huashan tight and ordered a search for the Sword Saint’s place of seclusion. The search had continued ever since.

“Grandmaster really is something. He’s an amazing person.”

“I’d only heard about him. I didn’t know he was this extraordinary either.”

“If that messenger pigeon hadn’t arrived, we would have been stuck searching Huashan too.”

In the midst of all that, the messenger pigeon that flew in from Shanxi Province had been a light of salvation.

After much deliberation, Huashan’s leaders had decided to dispatch the exceptional talents known as the Three Plum Blossom Elites.

“But what about that person named Cheongpung? Have you ever met him, Senior Brother?”

“Yes. Once, ten years ago.”

A disciple whom Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had raised like a son—like a grandson.

Baek Museong had been there that day ten years ago as well. The eyes of Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong, gleamed.

“I’m looking forward to it. I wonder how much he’s grown.”

Chapter 150

The training ground was so vast and empty that it looked desolate. Sweat trickled down the forehead of a young man sitting cross-legged.

What should I have done?

He closed his eyes and sank into thought. One person came to mind.

He recalled Cheongpung's crude blue-steel sword and his footwork. The smile that had vanished the moment he began displaying his martial arts.

At last, from the pitch-black darkness, a figure wrapped in violet light-flames burst forth.

Cheongpung.

Grandson of the Sword God Mae Jonghak. His disciple. It didn't matter what he called him.

What mattered was the fact that four days ago, he had exchanged martial arts with Cheongpung—and lost.

Jin Mukyung had shut himself away in the training ground and his quarters ever since. He staved off hunger with fasting pills and drove away sleep by training.

He had no need for warm food or honey-sweet rest.

I lost. Completely.

Barely three hundred exchanges. Even considering that his condition hadn't been normal, he had fallen far too easily.

Who was he? A genius who had reached the Peak realm at barely twenty and set the Central Plains abuzz.

Heaven Shaking Sword. One of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes… What a joke. Was this all I amounted to?

The grand titles attached to someone as mediocre as himself seemed laughable, nothing more than empty reputations. And yet the way he had secretly held himself in high regard left him feeling hollow.

Wasn't that the very definition of hypocrisy?

Who was it that said the world was vast?

The Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes. The Four Seas and Five Lakes.

How many masters lay hidden across this vast continent?

Only after meeting Cheongpung did Jin Mukyung understand what those words truly meant.

I was a frog in a well.

Heaven's Gate Temple was undoubtedly the finest educational institution in the orthodox Murim, but not every genius under heaven became one of its students.

The direct descendants of the Five Great Families and the true-line disciples of the Nine Sects and One Gang were too busy inheriting their sects' secret ultimate techniques.

Cheongpung was one of them. They had been born outside the well and had lived there all along.

Wait for me, Cheongpung. And all the rest of you.

The instant Jin Mukyung's eyes opened halfway, his body shot upward like lightning and light burst from his waist.

Whoosh!

Sword Energy.

Silver Sword Energy slashed relentlessly in every direction, denser and clearer than it had been four days ago—no, than ever before.

His duel with Cheongpung had given him insight and fighting spirit. His vague goal of simply becoming stronger had finally gained focus.

Swish, swish, swish, swish!

Jin Mukyung's sword did not stop after that, either.

Not until he was exhausted, utterly spent, and collapsed…

In Murim, the dantian is called the qi sea.

The qi sea. The sea of qi. The place where all the internal energy in the body begins and gathers. Whoever coined the term had chosen very well.

Ding!

SYSTEM

Qi circulation has begun.
Follow the formula of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique to circulate your internal energy.

The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique had already reached the eighth stage. Following the path I had traveled hundreds—no, thousands—of times before, I sent forty-five years of internal energy coursing through it.

Hot.

The Scorching Yang Qi I had gained from taking the Blazing Flame Divine Pill amounted to a full half-jiazi.[845]

That tremendous energy, boiling like lava, swept through the blood vessels throughout my body. Its unstoppable momentum filled me with anticipation.

[845] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Half a jiazi is thirty years.

Maybe I can do it now…

Whenever I circulated my qi, there was one place where I always got stuck.

Two acupoints, sealed tight as iron gates, refused to let my internal energy pass. I had only recently learned that they were called the Conception and Governor Vessels.[846]

The Conception and Governor Vessels.[847] I've seen those plenty of times in novels.

Wasn't this a stage every protagonist in a martial arts novel passed through at least once?

In martial arts novels, opening the Conception and Governor Vessels[848] was standard, and Bone Transformation[849] was an optional extra. Of course, I wasn't a protagonist or even a supporting character, so I had been forced to retreat every time.

That was then. Until now.

Fifteen years of internal energy hadn't been enough. It was like ramming a compact car whose airbags didn't even work straight into a boulder.

But things were different now. Add half a jiazi[850] of Scorching Yang Qi, and that compact car turned into a military tank.

This is worth a shot.

No. I had to succeed.

It was a mountain I absolutely had to overcome if I wanted to advance to a higher realm.

I drew up my internal energy as its momentum reached its peak, split it into two streams, and launched them toward the Conception and Governor Vessels.[851]

Boom!

The collision between my internal energy and the acupoints sounded like thunder. At the same time, a sharp, tingling pain reverberated through my spine and lower abdomen.

The stronger the impact, the more vicious the recoil. But I couldn't give up now. Gritting my teeth, I rammed my internal energy against them again and again.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

What the fuck is this?

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[846] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

[847] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

[848] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

[849] Bone Transformation is a martial-arts-fiction transformation that refines and renews the body.

[850] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Half a jiazi is thirty years.

[851] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

I'd put my body through hell in my own way. Getting stabbed was practically routine, and I'd even had my internal organs damaged before.

But this was a completely different kind of pain.

Fine, my back hurts—but why does it hurt there?

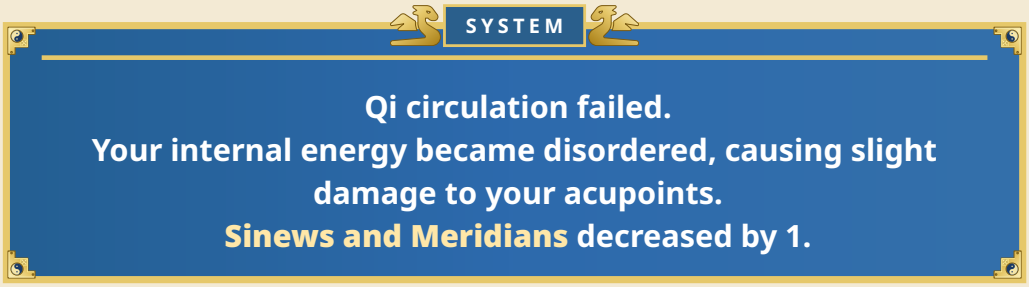
A part of a man as important as his life throbbed painfully. It felt as if someone were repeatedly squeezing it with all their strength, then letting go.

Opening the Conception and Governor Vessels[852] felt like it would earn me an incredible reward. Like enduring this would make me a Peak master…

But the more I battered the acupoints with my internal energy, the yellower my vision became.

"Ugh!"

Beep! Beep!



My balls already hurt enough to make me want to die, and now my Sinews and Meridians had dropped too.

Clutching the still-throbbing area, I collapsed facedown on the bed.

"Ugh! Uuugh!"

The riper the rice, the lower it bows its head. The more a man's vital spot hurts, the lower he bends at the waist.

I stayed facedown for a long while as though praying, and the pain gradually subsided.

"Huff, huff."

I'd almost ended up like Hong Jin.[853]

I had just sprawled out on the bed, drenched in sweat, when hurried footsteps approached and uninvited guests burst in.

"Captain!"

"Benefactor!"

Hyuk Mujin and Cheongpung charged through the door, then stopped short when they saw me.

"What happened… Whoa."

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[852] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

[853] Hong Jin is a delicate-looking, high-voiced man Taekyung met earlier.

“Benefactor, what are you doing?”

“Huh? What about it?”

Only after asking did I realize what I looked like.

“Oh.”

A hot-blooded young man in his twenties, in a sealed room, soaked in sweat despite the middle of winter, lying on a bed with one hand clutching that particular spot.

Hmm. There was definitely room for misunderstanding.

I calmly opened my mouth.

“You’ve got it wrong.”

After a brief silence, Hyuk Mujin’s eyes curved into a smile.

“I know. I know all about it.”

“No, that’s not it.”

“Oh, come on. Why are you acting like this? We’re both men of the world.”

“What do you mean, men of the world, you lunatic?”

“You’re still pretending you don’t know. Do I look that narrow-minded to you?”

“I’m telling you, it’s really not what you think!”

“Did it feel good? If you haven’t finished yet, should I step outside?”

“I haven’t even started!”

“Oh, then you were just about to start. Should I come back when you’re done?”

“I’m not doing it! I wasn’t planning to!”

“It’s all right. There’s nothing to be embarrassed about. I do it five times a day when I’m in good shape.”

“Is that actually true…? No, wait, you little—”

Chaos. Destruction. Ruin.

As the misunderstanding only deepened with every passing moment, Cheongpung tilted his head.

“What’s the misunderstanding? What do you know?”

“Young Hero Cheongpung, you really don’t know why the Captain is like that?”

“I don’t. Does he need to pee?”

“Good heavens, how can this be? I’ll explain it just once, so take it to heart. All of this becomes flesh and blood. I’m telling you, it’ll change your life.”

“Yes!”

“Where is the Captain’s hand right now? Answer me.”

“On his lower half.”

“That’s right. And what’s on his lower half?”

“Underclothes.”

“Underclothes! Good. You’re almost there. Now, what’s inside the underclothes?”

“Huh? But his hand isn’t on his lower half anymore.”

“What?”

“Benefactor’s hand is coming this way.”

“Gasp.”

Smack!

Thud.

It was a slap aimed precisely at his lower jaw. Hyuk Mujin crumpled with a peaceful expression, and Cheongpung caught him.

“I haven’t heard the whole thing yet.”

“…What would you do with the rest?”

“He said hearing it would become flesh and blood and change my life. Isn’t that a good thing?”

“…”

Come to think of it, that wasn’t entirely wrong.

Cheongpung gazed dejectedly at the unconscious sex-education teacher.

“But what were you doing while holding your lower half?”

“…”

Anyone overhearing this really would get the wrong idea.

“…And that’s what happened.”

By the time I finished my explanation, packed to the brim with facts, Hyuk Mujin had regained consciousness. He muttered sullenly, “Then you should’ve just said so from the start.”

“Whew. Do you really want me to beat you to death today?”

“Ah, I’ll pass. My head is still ringing.”

Hyuk Mujin winced and shook his head.

“But why did you suddenly try to open the Conception and Governor Vessels?[854] You’re not a Peak internal-energy master, and you don’t have the guts to risk something like that.”

“…I just tried it once.”

“What?”

“Forget it. You’re annoying, so shut up.”

I waved dismissively at the wide-eyed Hyuk Mujin.

It was too embarrassing to admit that watching Jin Mukyung and Cheongpung’s duel four days ago had made me want to become far stronger than I was now.

[854] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

"Anyway, just know that I failed spectacularly. I couldn't do it properly because it hurt down there. Why is this happening?"

"How would I know? I'm not a physician, or a Peak master like a certain someone."

Hyuk Mujin and I naturally turned our gazes to the side. The aforementioned "Peak master" blinked and opened his mouth.

"Hmm. I've heard something about it from my grandfather."

Hyuk Mujin now knew Cheongpung's identity too. We both exclaimed in anticipation.

"Ohhh."

"Oooooh."

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was one of the greatest masters under heaven. When it came to martial arts, we would believe him even if he claimed he could make fermented soybean blocks out of red beans.

"What did he say?"

"He said that if I mishandled the Conception Vessel,[855] I might not be able to perform as a man, and that the same was true of the Governor Vessel.[856] What else did he say? Oh, right!"

Cheongpung, who had been thinking hard, smacked his forehead.

"He told me to leave them alone because they'd open on their own with time. He said I'd become a cripple if I mishandled both of them."

"…?"

"…?"

What the hell is he talking about?

Hyuk Mujin and I exchanged glances almost simultaneously.

"Do the Conception and Governor Vessels[857] normally open with time?"

"I don't know. That's the first I've heard of it, too."

"But it can't be nonsense. The man's the Sword Saint."

"Right. Maybe it takes a very long time?"

"How long?"

"How would I know? My father is almost sixty. Should I ask him?"

"Oh, ask him whether his Conception and Governor Vessels[858] have opened?"

"Yes."

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[855] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

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[858] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

“Is he a martial artist?”

“He owns the Hyuk Family Textile Shop.”

“Try not to speak unless you have to. Listening to you is infuriating.”

“Yes.”

I pitied myself for taking someone like this around as my subordinate.

I heaved a deep sigh and spoke to Cheongpung.

“Could you explain in a little more detail? Surely your grandfather didn’t say only that…”

“He said exactly that.”

“…Really? Word for word?”

“I don’t lie to my Benefactor.”

That was true. Cheongpung wasn’t sly enough to lie.

Whether it was his nature or the environment in which he’d grown up, he was so honest and guileless that, to put it unkindly, he seemed stupid.

Cheongpung added with an aggrieved expression, “And my grandfather isn’t a liar either. I waited, too, and mine opened. Not both of them—only the Governor Vessel.[859]”

“I’m not saying the Sword Saint lied… Wait. What did you just say?”

“Young Hero Cheongpung, what was that? You opened the Conception and Governor Vessels?[860]”

“Oh, only the Governor Vessel[861] for now. Maybe it’s because I’m still young.”

I stammered, “H-How did you open it?”

“Two years ago, I was just training when I suddenly felt strange, and then—bang!”

“Bang?”

“That’s how it opened.”

“…”

“…”

“I thought it was strange, so I asked my grandfather. He said it was enlightenment. Hehe.”

This was hopeless. We were far too different.

The Sword Saint had been right that the Conception and Governor Vessels[862] would open naturally with time.

The problem was that it only applied to Cheongpung.

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[859] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

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[862] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Conception and Governor Vessels are paired pathways running along the front and back of the torso.

The guy smiling innocently in front of me was practically a new breed of human, fundamentally different from someone like me.

Genius. Talent bestowed by heaven. That's what this is.

Cheongpung and Jin Mukyung had both been born with talent entirely unlike mine. There was nothing I could do about that.

When I remained silent for a while, Cheongpung cautiously watched my expression.

"Benefactor, did I do something wrong?"

"No. You didn't do anything wrong."

"Really? That's a relief."

Watching Cheongpung sigh with relief, I licked my dry lips.

"But, um…"

"Yes?"

"Could I ask you for a favor?"

"Anything."

Damn it. Now that I had to say it, the words wouldn't come out.

I had thick skin. I'd been called brazen and shameless before.

But why was this one sentence so difficult?

"Benefactor?"

With great difficulty—truly, great difficulty—I forced out the words.

"Could you help me with my training?"

"Of course. Certainly."

"What?"

"I'll help you. With your training."

The moment I looked into his clear eyes, I finally understood why I had hesitated.

It was competitive pride.

Competitive pride that made me unwilling to accept help from this guy, of all people.

Not because I disliked him, but because he was an opponent I wanted to defeat solely through my own strength.

"…Aren't you agreeing a little too easily?"

"I owe you a lot, Benefactor. I'll teach you plenty of good things. Oh, except for the martial arts my grandfather warned me not to teach!"

Teach me?

A corner of my petty heart grew uncomfortable. And that made it clear.

I wanted to defeat this guy. I wanted to stand on equal footing with him.

But to do that…

"Then I'll be counting on you."

I had to learn. What else could I do?
Turns out I had a thicker hide than I thought.

Chapter 151

The pavilion where I was staying had only been completed a few days ago.

Apparently, Jin Mukyung had made such a spectacular mess on his first day back at the Jin Family of Taiyuan that they tore down the old pavilion and built a new one.

The important thing is, I have a training ground now.

There was no way Jin Wikyung, who absolutely melted whenever it came to his younger siblings, would have cut corners.

The inside of the pavilion was decorated far better than before, but more importantly, I now had a private training ground of my own.

“They brought in the finest carpenters and stonemasons in the area to build it.”

“Really?”

I looked around the training ground as Hyuk Mujin gave me the sales pitch like a real estate agent.

There was a high wall to keep out prying eyes and a spacious training ground. In one corner, weapons for training—what were commonly called the eighteen traditional weapons—rested on a rack.

“Look here in particular. See how the floor has a bluish tint?”

“You’re right. It looks like stone.”

“Yes, it’s called bluestone. And it isn’t just nice to look at. Want to see?”

Bang! Bang!

“Hey!”

I shouted in surprise when Hyuk Mujin suddenly stomped down with all his strength.

This bastard had completely lost his mind just because it wasn’t his training ground.

But Hyuk Mujin pointed at the floor as though nothing had happened.

“Now, before you get angry, look at the floor. It’s perfectly fine.”

Really?

At Hyuk Mujin’s Level, he was more or less qualified to be called a First Rate martial artist, yet the floor had only suffered a few minor scratches. They must have spent quite a bit of money.

“High-quality bluestone is extremely hard. It takes quite a lot to break it.”

“Nice.”

“Wow, they have things like this too? I’ve only ever trained on dirt.”

Cheongpung tapped the floor in fascination, then lightly stamped his foot.

Crack!

"Huh? It broke."

"…"

"…"

You little bastard. Who told you to put internal energy into your foot?

I stared sadly at the training-ground floor, which had been smashed before I had even gotten to use it properly, then turned toward Hyuk Mujin.

"I-I didn't do anything wrong."

"I didn't say anything."

"You just cursed me out with your eyes."

"Want me to do it with my mouth too?"

"…No, thank you. I'll be going, then. I just remembered something important."

Look at him trying to casually edge away.

I grabbed him by the back of the neck as he tried to sneak off.

"Why? Why?"

"Where do you think you're going? You have nothing to do."

"Nothing to do? Do you think I'm some idle wastrel? I told you, I have something important to take care of."

"Then why have you spent the last two days lounging around my pavilion?"

"…"

"I heard you got reward leave. My eldest brother told me."

Cheongpung shot his hand into the air and shouted,

"Wow, reward leave! I want some too!"

"…Young Hero Cheongpung, are you making fun of me?"

"You there, clean up the broken pieces of bluestone."

"Oh, yes!"

What a pointlessly cheerful guy.

Meanwhile, Hyuk Mujin, still kicking his feet in my grip, let out a deep sigh.

"Whew. Fine. Just hit me once and get it over with."

"Why would I hit you?"

"Isn't that why you grabbed me?"

"Of course not. Do I look like the kind of violent bastard who'd hit someone for no reason?"

"Yes."

"Some people repay a thousand-nyang[863] debt with a single word, but you earn a thousand blows with your mouth."

Smack!

"Guh!"

[863] Nyang is a historical Korean unit of money, not a denomination of modern won.

“Don’t be such a baby.”

Hyuk Mujin rubbed his red, swollen forehead.

“You hit me once, so that settles it, right? I’ll be going now.”

“Going where? Stay here.”

“What good would staying do me? You’ll obviously just send me on pointless errands.”

When I merely stared at him without answering, Hyuk Mujin continued grumbling.

“You may have forgotten, Captain, but I’m a martial artist too. If I want to become Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion, I need to train my ass off.”

“Who told you not to train?”

“Huh?”

Was he stupid, or had the thought simply never occurred to him? I clicked my tongue at Hyuk Mujin, who still hadn’t caught on.

“I’m saying you should train with us here.”

“…Me? Here?”

He stared back and forth between Cheongpung and me in bewilderment before stammering out a response.

“Am I really allowed to?”

“No reason it wouldn’t be. Is that okay with you, Cheongpung?”

Cheongpung, who had been proudly examining the pieces of bluestone he had somehow managed to fit back together, nodded.

“I don’t mind. But you have to buy me lots of candied hawthorn skewers[864] later.”

“…Are you possessed by a ghost who died because they couldn’t get any candied hawthorn skewers[865]?”

“A ghost? Benefactor, is there a ghost attached to me right now?”

“No, that’s not what I meant.”

“Wow! A ghost! A ghost!”

“God, this is driving me crazy.”

This guy was completely out of his mind.

I shook my head repeatedly and looked away from Cheongpung. Hyuk Mujin was still standing there in a daze.

“So, what’s it going to be? You don’t want to?”

Snapping out of it, he vigorously shook his head.

“I do. I’d love to… but are you sure I can join you?”

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[864] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating hawthorn fruit on skewers in hardened sugar.

[865] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating hawthorn fruit on skewers in hardened sugar.

"I told you, you can. What, did you commit some crime?"

"Still, it's an unwritten rule of the Murim not to show others your martial arts…"

It was the same among Hunters, too.

It wasn't as pronounced as in the Murim, where people killed one another, but Hunters were also reluctant to reveal the full extent of their abilities.

And the higher a Hunter's rank, the more true that was.

Mediocre low-rank Hunters had no money, so they packed together and trained like regulars at a neighborhood gym. But once a Hunter reached the middle ranks and had some money to spare, getting a private training room was practically a given.

"Captain and Cheongpung are masters who inherited the secret arts of your respective sects, but I'm different. I won't be of much help while the two of you train."

"Hmm. That's true."

"…Right."

I continued speaking as Hyuk Mujin lowered his head with a dejected expression.

"That's why you should take this chance to learn properly and make yourself useful."

"What?"

"How long are you going to keep getting your ass kicked? Is becoming Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion the goal of your life? If you're going to advance with me into broader waters, you need to get stronger too."

"…!"

"Just train hard. Instead of wasting time worrying about whether you're qualified, keep your mouth shut, be shameless about taking the opportunity, and train even if you have to cut into your sleep."

That was what I had done. For the past several years, I had struggled desperately to survive just one more day.

I had even waited hand and foot on senior Hunters, doing everything I could to learn one more thing from them. Then, through blood and sweat, I had absorbed those lessons and made them my own.

Having gone through that myself, I understood Hyuk Mujin's hesitation. At the same time, it frustrated me.

He even has outstanding talent.

Martial artists and Hunters were different. Hunters received their abilities overnight, while martial artists built their skills from the ground up, one layer at a time.

In that sense, Hyuk Mujin's talent was considerable.

I only have to compare him with the deadwood among the Five Gates of Shanxi to see that.

They had been born into martial families and practiced martial arts from childhood.

Hyuk Mujin, on the other hand, began learning martial arts at an age when his bones and muscles had already hardened, yet he reached the First Rate realm in only five years.

Of course, that was based on Level alone, but even in a real fight, he could easily overpower men of their caliber.

And it isn't just talent… He's got grit.

Five years. That was how long it had taken the son of a textile-shop owner to become a First Rate master. Hyuk Mujin had said that he had not returned to his family home even once during that entire time.

I remembered something he had told me a few days ago.

"I started learning martial arts a little late. What else could I do if I wanted to catch up? I had no choice but to work ten or twenty times harder than everyone else."

Easy to say, but not something an ordinary person could do.

It meant that he had continued his grueling efforts while sacrificing even his sleep. In that sense, Hyuk Mujin and I clearly had something in common.

The problem is that our inferiority complexes are similar too.

That was why he couldn't readily accept the goodwill Cheongpung and I were offering. He knew this was a great opportunity, but he couldn't help wondering whether a nobody like him really belonged here.

Those feelings were holding him back. I looked him straight in the eye.

"I've made the offer. The decision is yours. If you want to keep going the way you are, I won't stop you."

"…May I ask you one thing?"

I nodded. After a brief silence, Hyuk Mujin parted his lips.

"Why are you going this far for me?"

"You said you were my right arm, didn't you? Or was it my heart?"

"Pardon?"

"What do you mean, 'pardon'? You went around saying that yourself."

"And every time I did, you told me to stop talking nonsense."

"That was just something I said. If I disliked you, would I have kept you around all this time?"

"Wasn't it because you were bored? Sometimes you seemed to enjoy hitting me when your hands got restless."

"…"

Just how much of a piece of trash did this bastard think I was?

When I glared at him, Hyuk Mujin hurriedly pretended nothing had happened.

“Ahem. Ahem, ahem…”

“Listen, if I hadn’t planned to raise you up, I would have gone around alone a long time ago. Why would I lug around deadweight like you?”

“Deadweight? Can you really change your story that easily? A moment ago, I was your right arm or your heart.”

“Right arm, my ass. At your current level, I’ll let you be my little toe.”

“Wow. That’s harsh. Really.”

He sounded hurt, but he couldn’t hide the corners of his mouth, which kept rising.

Right arm or little toe, they were both important parts of the body. That fact didn’t change.

Feeling strangely embarrassed, I shouted, “Enough! Are you doing this or not?”

“I’m actually a martial arts genius, you know. I might copy everything you do. Are you sure that’s okay?”

“Bullshit. Copy it if you can.”

“Really?”

“Ask one more time and I’ll hit you so it really hurts.”

Hyuk Mujin broke into a broad smile.

“I’ll do it.”

His voice sounded lighter, as though he had shed an old skin.

Hyuk Mujin and I sat on the floor of the training ground and looked at Cheongpung. Taking a seat was the basic requirement before the real lecture began.

“All right. Let’s begin.”

“I look forward to learning from you, Young Hero Cheongpung.”

“Yes, yes! Hoo, hoo…”

Every time Cheongpung took a heavy breath, white steam puffed from his nose into the cold winter air.

What was wrong with him all of a sudden?

“Are you all right?”

“I’m fine!”

“You startled me. Why are you suddenly acting like this?”

“Oh. Um, well…”

Cheongpung hesitated, then spoke with a face flushed bright red.

“This is my first time teaching anyone, so I’m too excited and worked up… Whew, give me a moment.”

"…"

"…"

I knew this would happen.

Perhaps he was still nervous, because Cheongpung spoke in a trembling voice.

"Th-then I'll begin."

"Don't make it so stiff. Just relax."

"R-relax?"

"Yes. Relax. Just teach us in whatever way you're comfortable with, Cheongpung."

"The way I'm most comfortable…"

"The way your grandfather taught you."

"Oh. What an easy solution!"

Hyuk Mujin and I looked at Cheongpung with a mixture of anticipation and curiosity.

This was the teaching method of the Sword Saint himself. How had that great martial artist raised this genius?

It must be something completely different.

As Cheongpung sank into thought, a smile appeared on his lips. Apparently, merely thinking about the method put him in a good mood.

"Oh, I thought of something. This training will probably help both of you a great deal, too."

"Ohhh."

"Oooooh. What is it?"

"Do you see that?"

We turned in the direction Cheongpung was pointing.

Hyuk Mujin spoke first, and I finished the thought.

"That's…"

"The training hall."

It stood roughly two hundred jang[866] from the training ground. I had a pretty good idea what kind of training he meant, and a quiet laugh escaped me.

It was the classic touch-and-go method: repeatedly running like hell to touch the destination and come back.

I expected something special from the Sword Saint, but I guess he wasn't that different.

It was certainly a classic, but it was an effective exercise for building endurance and strengthening the lower body.

I stood and began stretching leisurely.

"Do we just go there and come back?"

[866] A jang is ten cheok, about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet). Two hundred jang is about 606 meters (1,990 feet).

Cheongpung tilted his head.

“Huh? You’ve done this before?”

“Until I was sick of it.”

“Oh, I see. That’s a relief.”

Cheongpung smiled brightly and pointed to me, then Hyuk Mujin.

“Then I’ll give you half a shichen[867] and one shichen[868], respectively.”

“…?”

“…?”

“What?”

I asked in confusion.

“Half a shichen[869]? What do you mean?”

“Didn’t you say you’d done it until you were sick of it? That should be plenty of time for you.”

“That’s true, but… Ah, I get it. Do we have to make nonstop round trips for half a shichen[870]?”

“No. Once will be enough for now. I’ll wait for you at the summit.”

“What? The summit?”

“Yes. There.”

This time, I saw it clearly. Cheongpung’s raised fingertip was pointing at the cliff behind the training hall.

Hyuk Mujin and I dropped our jaws at the same time.

Holy shit. What the hell is that?

The height was impossibly vast. Even judging by eye, it was a steep cliff hundreds of jang[871] high. My vision went dark, and my hands and feet began to tremble.

If it affected me this badly, Hyuk Mujin had to be even worse.

“Are you saying… we have to climb that?”

“Yes! I picked it because it’s about the same height as the place I climbed every day when I was little.”

“…”

“…”

“Ah, that brings back memories. I fell halfway down and nearly died twice. It really hurt back then.”

“…!”

“…!”

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[867] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[868] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[869] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[870] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[871] A jang is ten cheok, about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet). Two hundred jang is about 606 meters (1,990 feet).

He was insane. The Sword Saint was insane, and this bastard was insane too.

Chapter 152

"Yaaawn."

A middle-aged martial artist let out a long yawn and glanced to the side.

Only a few paces away, the new recruit who had been assigned here today was standing stiffly and staring straight ahead.

What a guy. He's got one hell of a build.

Limbs like pestles. Broad, squared shoulders.

Judging by his size alone, anyone might have suspected he hailed from the Hebei Peng Family, renowned for its sturdy physiques.

Come to think of it, I don't even know his name yet.

The weather was cold, and there were still three shichen[872] left in his shift.

On days like this, you had to flap your gums to make the time pass faster and keep warm. The middle-aged martial artist quietly opened his mouth.

"Hey there."

"Yes, sir!"

"Good heavens, did you swallow a thunderbolt? Why are you shouting so loud?"

"I'm sorry!"

"No need to apologize. Is it because you're new? It's good to see someone so full of spirit."

"Ah, thank you."

"Yeah, yeah. That's right."

The middle-aged martial artist smiled, pleased. They had only exchanged a few words, but the kid seemed decent. His manner was straightforward, and unlike young people these days, he was polite too.

For a man who was slowly being treated like an old-timer fit only for the back rooms, he had found himself a pretty good conversational partner.

"Is your surname Peng, by any chance?"

"No. It's Jang."

"I was only curious. You've got quite the physique. I wondered if you might belong to some distant collateral branch of the Hebei Peng Family."

The new martial artist scratched the back of his head.

"I've been pretty strong ever since I was a snot-nosed kid."

"I thought so. Your limbs are packed with muscle. Reminds me of myself when I was young."

Of course, that was utter nonsense. But despite his appearance, the new martial artist was perceptive enough to immediately bow deeply.

---

[872] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

“Compared to you in your youth, Senior, I’m nothing.”

“Come now, none of this ‘Senior’ business. Call me hyung[873] from now on. Ah, my surname is Hong.”

“Yes, hyung[874]!”

“Heh heh. Looks like I’ve gained a good little brother. So, Little Brother Jang, when did you join our family?”

“It’s already been several years.”

“What? That can’t be right. If a man like you, with a general’s bearing, had joined, I would’ve heard about it long ago…”

Hong had served the Jin Family of Taiyuan for nearly twenty years. As something of an old fixture, he knew exactly which martial artists came and went.

“Ah, I haven’t been a martial artist for even a month. Before that, I was a servant doing odd jobs here and there. I mostly worked out of sight, so you may not have noticed me.”

“Ahh, I see.”

Hong looked at the new recruit with fresh interest.

A servant who became a martial artist. It wasn’t unheard of, but it wasn’t common either.

“You must have a powerful backer.”

“Pardon?”

“Oh, come now. Don’t play dumb when you know exactly what I mean. Do you think it’s easy for a new recruit to land this post?”

Grinning, Hong poked him in the side.

“Who is it? The Chief Steward is far too strict to be behind it, so did you manage to secure a solid connection somewhere in the leadership?”

“Well, I…”

“Just tell me quietly. I’ll keep it to myself. Is it the Outer Hall Master? Or the Iron Sword Squad Leader?”

The Lesser Family Head sent me here.

The new martial artist, Jang Childeuk, swallowed the words that had nearly slipped out.

People had loose tongues. If he told the truth, the rumor would spread before sunrise tomorrow.

I can’t cause trouble for the Lesser Family Head!

When it came to loyalty toward the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Childeuk was no less devoted than any martyr.

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[873] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[874] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

He avoided the middle-aged martial artist's intensely curious gaze and opened his mouth.

"By the way, was this really such a difficult place to get into?"

The middle-aged martial artist looked disappointed at the change of subject and clicked his tongue. Since Childeuk clearly didn't want to say, pressing him further would be a bit awkward.

"Tsk. You said you'd been with the family for several years, right?"

"That's right. As a servant, though."

"Then how many times did you come to the training hall during those years?"

"Exactly twice."

"Right? Now, take a good look around."

"Right now?"

"Or would you rather do it next year?"

Jang Childeuk looked around as instructed.

The Jin Family's rear was completely enclosed by steep cliffs. Beneath them yawned a vast cavern—the entrance to the training hall.

Aside from Childeuk and Hong, not a soul was in sight.

"What do you think?"

"It's deserted."

"Right? How many people do you think come here in a day?"

"How many?"

Hong answered indifferently.

"No one."

"Pardon?"

"Other than the people who come to change shifts every four shichen[875], nobody comes here. Ah, there is a servant who delivers meals."

"But… this is the training hall, isn't it?"

"It is. But does anyone train here? No. The Third Young Master came in and out a few times after causing trouble, but that's about it."

What an absurd thing to say.

Come to think of it, despite the name, Childeuk had never seen anyone actually training there.

The training ground, on the other hand, was always crawling with martial artists, no matter the season.

"Then why are we guarding this place?"

"It's a symbol."

"A symbol?"

[875] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

“Long ago, Founder Jin Muryang trained here. According to legend, he suddenly attained enlightenment while training on this cliff and unleashed his martial arts. With One Strike, he blasted open the base of the cliff.”

Jang Childeuk’s jaw dropped.

He remembered hearing legends about Founder Jin Muryang. Hadn’t he been one of the greatest masters under heaven some three hundred years ago?

But how could such a thing be possible with a human body?

“Is—is that really true?”

“It happened hundreds of years ago. What does it matter whether it’s true or false? There’s a much more important fact.”

“…Yes?”

“If you sit around in front of this training hall for a few shichen[876] every day, your monthly pay arrives like clockwork. That’s what matters. The only downside is that time passes damnably slowly.”

Hong grinned and patted Childeuk on the shoulder.

“Congratulations. You’ve been assigned to the finest post every martial artist in the family dreams of. What they call a cushy post.”

“…”

Childeuk’s face twisted.

It would be one thing if he were old enough to retire at any moment, but he was still in his prime. He had no intention of wasting his time in the training hall with nothing to do.

Oblivious to Childeuk’s thoughts, Hong pulled a strip of jerky from his robes and began chewing.

“Want one?”

“I’m fine.”

“Why? It’s salty and pretty good. Looking at the sky while chewing jerky makes time pass quickly.”

The middle-aged martial artist leaned against the entrance to the training hall and tilted his head back to look at the sky.

“Well, would you look at that. The sky is so clear. Just looking at it makes my chest feel wide open.”

Jang Childeuk reluctantly glanced upward.

As Hong had said, the weather was clear. Wisps of cloud drifted slowly across the blue sky, accompanied by several black specks.

“What are those?”

“Birds, probably.”

---

[876] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

As Childeuk stared blankly at the sky, his gaze drifted toward the dizzyingly high cliff. Suddenly, his eyes narrowed.

“What about that thing clinging to the cliff?”

“The cliff? What’s on the cliff?”

“Yes. It’s pretty big.”

“Dunno. Must be a pretty big bird. Hold on, I brought a bottle of liquor somewhere…”

Without even looking where Childeuk was pointing, Hong pulled a small porcelain bottle from his robes.

“It looks a little too big to be a bird.”

“It could be a Heavenly Eagle. Those things are as big as people. They aren’t ordinary hawks.”

“Wow. It really is as big as a person.”

“They’re even called spirit creatures. I heard their wingspan alone is more than a jang[877]. I’ve only seen one from a distance, myself.”

“But, hyung[878].”

“What? Why do you keep calling me?”

“Do Heavenly Eagles fall, too?”

“What the hell are you talking about?”

Hong, who had been tipping the bottle toward his mouth, hurriedly looked at the cliff.

At that dizzying height, a massive dot was plummeting rapidly.

“Aaaaaaah!”

Childeuk marveled.

“It really is a spirit creature. Its scream sounds exactly like a person.”

“That’s a person, you lunatic!”

“Whaaa!”

“Move! Move!”

The instant Hong screamed, a person crashed into the ground amid a shower of stone fragments.

Boom! Rumble, rumble!

Rocks and dust burst in every direction. The two men swallowed at the same time.

“D-do you think he’s dead?”

“Try falling from that height. Even the Jade Emperor[879] would die.”

How had such a horrific calamity intruded upon their peaceful routine?

---

[877] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[878] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[879] The Jade Emperor is a deity in Daoist tradition who rules over heaven.

The middle-aged martial artist clutched his trembling chest and stared at the body lying facedown.

“What kind of madman falls from a cliff…”

“He looks young.”

“Does it matter whether he’s young or old? The important thing is that he’s dead.”

“That’s true, but…”

“Go turn him over.”

“M-me?”

“Who else is here besides you and me? Hurry!”

At the middle-aged martial artist’s shout, Jang Childeuk hesitantly began approaching the body.

He had only been a martial artist for a month. This was the first time he had ever witnessed someone die right in front of him.

“Huff, huff.”

The closer he got, the more clearly he could see the body.

Its limbs lay limp, and blood streamed from the back of its head as it lay facedown on the ground. Considering the height of the fall, the corpse looked surprisingly intact.

“M-may you be reborn in paradise.”

He squeezed his eyes shut and reached out to touch the body.

That was when it suddenly shot upright.

Crack!

The world flashed before Childeuk’s eyes, followed by a wave of excruciating pain.

He landed hard on his backside, his mouth hanging open, unaware that blood was streaming from both nostrils.

“Uh… uhhhh.”

“What in the… Ugh, ughhh!”

Hong’s legs gave out, and he collapsed.

“The corpse—the corpse is alive!”

“Ugh! It’s a jiangshi[880]! A jiangshi[881] has appeared!”

The dirt-covered stranger who had suddenly been written off as dead staggered to his feet.

His hair was wild, and blood vessels had burst in his eyes. He looked around, then ground his teeth.

“Fuck, Taecho Village[882] again?”

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[880] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.
[881] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.
[882] *Taecho* means “primordial” or “the beginning.”

Damn, that hurts.

Head, shoulders, knees, feet, knees, feet… There wasn't a single part of me that didn't ache. Luckily, I'd driven a dagger into the cliff and slowed my fall. Otherwise, I might have kicked the bucket.

Of course, the Muscles and Bones and Toughness stats I had steadily raised had helped, too.

"Ow, the back of my head is throbbing."

I touched the tender spot and found it wet with blood.

I tore off a strip of my sleeve and was wiping away the blood when—

"W-who are you?!"

"Reveal your identity, you scoundrel!"

Oh, right. These two guys were here too.

One of the two men pointing swords at me looked familiar. What was his name again…

"Jang Childeuk?"

Mr. Jang Childeuk, who had been working hard to manipulate public opinion at Honghwa Inn until just a few days ago, recoiled in terror.

"Gasp! How do you know my name?!"

"The jiangshi[883] is talking! It's bewitching people with its words!"

"…Who are you calling a jiangshi[884]? Can't you see I'm breathing just fine?"

The middle-aged man with the patchy beard glared at me and shouted.

"You evil creature! You can't fool my eyes. If you were human, you couldn't possibly be fine after falling from that height. Who sent you? The Demonic Cult? The Blood Cult? Or perhaps…"

"Taecho Village[885]! Hyung[886], that jiangshi[887] definitely said 'Taecho Village[888].'"

"That's right! You're a jiangshi[889] sent by Taecho Village[890]!"

The middle-aged man shouted as if he had finally figured it out, then suddenly stopped and asked Childeuk,

"But where is Taecho Village[891]?"

"I don't know either."

---

[883] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.
[884] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.
[885] *Taecho* means "primordial" or "the beginning."
[886] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[887] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.
[888] *Taecho* means "primordial" or "the beginning."
[889] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.
[890] *Taecho* means "primordial" or "the beginning."
[891] *Taecho* means "primordial" or "the beginning."

"…"

It would have been strange if he did.

I gave up on the conversation and wiped the dirt from my face with my sleeve.

The middle-aged man might not know me, but Childeuk knew my face well. This would be faster.

"Gasp! Third Young Master!"

"Yes. Long time no see."

"Little brother, the Third Young Master? What in the world are you talking about?"

"The Third Young Master has become a jiangshi[892]!"

"…"

How the hell did he reach that conclusion?

[892] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse from Chinese folklore, often depicted as a hopping vampire.

Chapter 153

"So…"

Jang Childeuk continued haltingly.

"You were training?"

"Yes."

"Were you perhaps practicing the Wall Lizard Technique?"

"I'm not entirely sure myself, but I think so."

The Wall Lizard Technique. I'd seen it plenty of times in wuxia novels.

Apparently, it was a martial art inspired by the way lizards climbed walls.

It was similar to the real-world sport of climbing, with two key differences.

First, unlike climbing, it used internal energy.

Second, there was no safety equipment.

This really is the Murim. No holding back.

If you fell, you were as good as dead. It was the ultimate macho martial art.

When I nodded, the two men stared at me as though I were a ghost.

"From this height?"

"Is that even possible?"

"It worked."

When I first heard Cheongpung suggest it, I'd wondered what kind of insane nonsense he was talking about, too. But once I tried it, it worked.

It had only seemed unrealistic because I'd never tried it before. It was no exaggeration to say my body had already entered the realm of the superhuman.

"Oh, my. Third Young Master, what if something serious happens to you?"

The middle-aged guy fussed over me, brushing the dust from my clothes.

Only three minutes ago, he had treated me like a jiangshi[893] from Taecho Village.[894] Now he was handling me as carefully as though I were his family's precious only son, three generations in the making.

"Come now. I think you should stop training for now and return to your quarters."

"Why?"

"What do you mean, why? You were lucky this time, but if you fall again, you could really die."

I waved a hand dismissively.

"It's fine. It's not like this was my first or second time."

"What?"

"This is already the fifth time. Why act surprised now?"

---

[893] A jiangshi is a reanimated corpse in Chinese folklore.

[894] Taecho Village evokes the starting village of a game, where beginners first appear.

“The fifth… time?”

“Yes. Five times.”

His trembling gaze darted between me and the steep cliff.

“H-how are you still alive?”

“It’s fine. Someone else has fallen more than ten times.”

“…”

“…”

“Looks like it’s about time for him to fall again… Oh, there he comes.”

I pointed toward a spot high up on the cliff. A black dot that grew larger by the second was followed by a piercing scream.

“Aaaaaaah! Caaaaaptain!”

The two men’s mouths fell open.

“My goodness. There really was someone else.”

“Who is that?”

“My right arm—no, my little toe.”

“What? What does that mean?”

“Never mind that. Shouldn’t we save him right now?”

“Save him? That?”

I shook my head.

Hyuk Mujin was a healthy adult man. If I tried to catch him as he fell from that height, it would end with more than just a broken bone somewhere.

“Just leave him alone. Don’t get involved and hurt yourselves.”

The two men screamed.

“He’s falling! He’s falling!”

“He’ll die if you leave him like this!”

“He won’t die.”

If that could kill him, he would’ve died more than ten times already.

But Hyuk Mujin had a lifeline—a sturdy rope that always saved him by the narrowest of margins.

“Aaaaaaah!”

Hyuk Mujin’s scream drew closer by the second. The instant even his horrified expression became clearly visible, a streak of light flashed above us.

It plunged downward as swiftly as a meteor, glowing with a soft purple light.

“W-what is that…?”

“What is it?”

I answered briefly.

“The Zaha Divine Technique.”

More precisely, it was someone channeling the Zaha Divine Technique.

The two men couldn’t see him, but I could clearly make out Cheongpung, wrapped in the technique’s distinctive purple qi.

He was grinning from ear to ear.

“Whoooooa!”

“…”

Look at that bastard having the time of his life.

His personality might have been a little unhinged, but his ability was in a league of its own. I could only marvel at what happened next.

How is that even possible?

Shooting downward like an arrow, Cheongpung snatched Hyuk Mujin by the waist in the blink of an eye.

Then he extended his palm toward the ground rushing up beneath them.

Bang! Boom-boom!

Once. Twice. Three times…

Compressed air exploded, gouging deep craters into the ground.

Was this what it would look like if an invisible giant pounded the earth with its fists?

Every time Cheongpung struck out with a palm, the frozen ground flipped over. The resulting recoil stopped the falling figure in midair.

A moment later, Cheongpung’s feet landed lightly on the ground.

“Whew, that was fun again. Right?”

Hyuk Mujin, already unconscious, groaned.

“Uhh… uhhh.”

“I knew you’d like it.”

“…”

What part of that made him look like he’d enjoyed himself?

Cheongpung cheerfully set Hyuk Mujin down, then acknowledged my presence.

“Oh, Benefactor! You’re still here?”

“I fell. Thanks to someone.”

I glared steadily at Cheongpung.

In fact, I had already had several chances to reach the summit. The problem was that Cheongpung was not exactly a man in possession of an ordinary state of mind.

“Hehe. It makes me happy to hear it was thanks to me.”

“Shut up! I would’ve reached the top ages ago if you hadn’t kept interfering from up there!”

“Gasp! Please calm down, Benefactor!”

“Calm down? You should’ve said that before rolling rocks at me!”

Think about it.

Climbing a cliff well over a hundred jang[895] high with your bare hands was hard enough. But every time I thought I'd made decent progress, rocks the size of children came tumbling down from above.

Cheongpung's innocent cries were an added bonus.

Benefactor, rocks are rolling!

Only someone who had experienced it could understand. Even if Shakyamuni[896] himself had been in my position, he would have strangled that bastard to death with his prayer beads.

Now that I think about it, I'm getting pissed off again.

Should I just charge him?

The moment I clenched my fist, Hyuk Mujin—who had been lying on the ground with only his fingers twitching—sprang upright with a scream.

"Aaaaaaaah!"

"Hey, hey. Breathe. Take a breath. You're on the ground."

"Huff, huff. Am I really alive?"

"Yeah, you idiot. You're still alive."

"W-water, please."

Cheongpung held out the bamboo tube hanging from his waist.

"Here."

"Thank…"

Hyuk Mujin absentmindedly accepted the bamboo tube, then froze stiff.

A moment later, he unleashed a lion's roar.

"You fucking bastard!"

Cheongpung recoiled in alarm as Hyuk Mujin went berserk, his eyes rolling back.

"W-why are you suddenly acting like this toward me?"

"You seriously don't know? Captain, catch that bastard!"

"I'm only doing exactly what my grandfather taught me."

"Get over here right now!"

"See you up there later, Benefactor!"

Cheongpung scampered away from Hyuk Mujin and kicked off the ground.

Boom!

He shot more than ten meters[897] into the air in a single bound, slapped onto the cliff, and began climbing with the Wall Lizard Technique.

Papapapapak!

---

[895] A jang is ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred jang is about 303 m (994 ft).

[896] Shakyamuni is a name for the historical Buddha.

[897] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

Now that was a true veteran.

Cheongpung vanished as quickly as if he'd been born walking on all fours. Hyuk Mujin sank to the ground.

"That bastard threw rocks at me. Rocks…"

I answered solemnly.

"I know. I saw you fall earlier. One hit you in the eye."

"He's completely insane. He throws rocks as big as a child's head."

"That's smaller than what he threw at me. He even threw dirt at me."

"Captain. I've made up my mind."

"About what?"

"I won't give up until I catch that bastard and beat the shit out of him. I swear it on the name of Hyuk Mujin, a true man."

Hyuk Mujin's eyes blazed.

I'd never seen him so fired up. Whatever he might be like inside, he'd always seemed cheerful and laid-back on the surface.

Could this be what Cheongpung was aiming for?

Was all of this Cheongpung's way of drawing out Hyuk Mujin's anger so that he would give it his all?

No. That wild man from Huashan didn't have the brains for that.

Well, whatever works.

I tossed a bundle to the fuming Hyuk Mujin.

"Keep it secure inside your clothes."

"What is this?"

"Fasting pills. I packed them before we started training."

Nothing was better for staving off hunger and replenishing energy. They were also small, light, and easy to carry.

"Eat some if you start running out of strength on the way up."

"We're surrounded by sheer drops. Where am I supposed to eat fasting pills? I'm going up there right now and cutting that bastard down in one stroke…"

"You're the one who'll die in one stroke."

Apparently, he wanted to use his newly learned Wall Lizard Technique to climb straight up Mount Beimang.[898] I smacked him on the back of the head.

"Ow!"

"And the cliff isn't sheer all the way up. There are ledges here and there, so find somewhere to stop and eat. Don't get impatient and fall. Take your time, and focus on making it in one attempt."

[898] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds. Here, climbing it means going to one's death.

"Hoo."

"Then let's go."

"Yes, Captain!"

Hyuk Mujin and I were standing before the cliff with determined expressions when—

"Um…"

"T-Third Young Master."

Right. These two were here, too.

Jang Childeuk and the middle-aged guy spoke hesitantly.

"Would it be all right if we reported this to the Lesser Family Head?"

"Considering the circumstances… If you suffer even an injury, Young Master, then we…"

I raised a hand to stop them.

I could easily guess what they were going to say next. I knew the perspective of ordinary employees better than anyone.

"Go ahead and report it. But…"

"But?"

"After your shift ends. How much longer do you have?"

"About three shichen."[899]

"That's enough."

I'd already spent half a day climbing the cliff.

I intended to conquer the damned thing within the remaining three shichen.[900]

This tall, steep, nameless cliff bore the full marks of time. Some sections were uneven, while others were smooth.

In some places, thick roots or rocks jutted out, making them easy to grab. In others, I had to wedge a single finger into a tiny crack and hang on.

This would be much easier if I could at least use internal energy or a weapon.

With internal energy, even solid rock would crumble like tofu.

If I took weapons from my inventory, I could drive daggers into the cliff like steps and climb that way.

I was putting myself through all this instead of taking the easy route because it was training…

Well, that was part of it. But every time I tried to use an easier method, Cheongpung would uncannily sense it and drop rocks on me.

[899] A shichen is a traditional period of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.

[900] A shichen is a traditional period of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.

Rattle, rattle.

A sudden shower of rock dust from above was an ominous sign.

Hyuk Mujin and I hurriedly shielded our heads with our arms and shouted.

“We didn’t do anything! Seriously, we didn’t! Don’t roll any rocks!”

“Uuughhh!”

A pale face cautiously poked out from above.

“Really?”

We nodded frantically.

We weren’t even halfway. If we were hit by a stone shower and fell now, all the bold claims we’d made before climbing would become a dark stain on our past.

“Please believe us!”

“Young Hero Cheongpung! No, Great Hero Cheongpung!”

“My grandfather always said there must never be any shortcuts in training. Martial arts are earned through blood and sweat.”

After delivering an entire speech, Cheongpung added magnanimously,

“I’ll let it go just this once.”

“…”

“…”

What an absolute tyrant.

Hyuk Mujin and I swallowed our outrage and resumed climbing.

One tiny mistake would send us plummeting all the way back down.

As a result, our senses grew sharper, and we had to pay tremendous attention to every single finger and toe.

If it weren’t winter, I would’ve reached the top ages ago…

The higher we climbed, the more treacherous the slope became and the smoother the surface grew.

The cliff was already slippery enough. On top of that, the scattered snow flurries that came almost every day and the wind blowing in from the northern Gaoyuan had turned it into one enormous sheet of ice.

Dead end. I can’t see a way forward.

As I worried at my lip, something suddenly caught my eye.

A crack in the rock blocked by a snowball that had not yet frozen.

It was a tiny space, barely wide enough for one finger. It would be difficult, but I had no other choice.

“Hup!”

I launched myself forward with a shout, simultaneously jamming my smallest finger—the little finger—precisely into the crack.

Thud.

My prediction had been only half right. I could break through the unfrozen snowball, but the crack was much shallower than I had expected.

It was barely one finger joint deep. And I had to support a body weighing 0.1 tons[901] with my little finger.

“Ungh.”

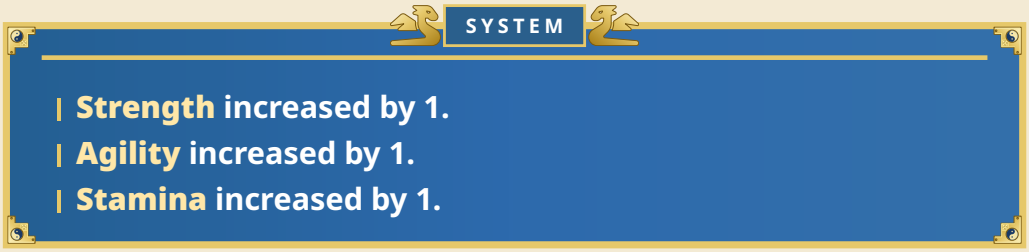
Even for me, this was asking a bit much.

To make matters worse, my finger was slowly slipping because of the moisture pooled inside the crack.

If I waste any more time, I’ll fall.

There was not much farther to go. I steadied my breathing and calmed the tension in my body. Using my little finger as a support, I lifted my entire body.

Physical ability truly worthy of the word superhuman.



Even my stats rose at just the right moment.

Just as I smiled triumphantly and reached toward the next crack—

Hup!

“Captain!”

Damn it. My breathing faltered at the worst possible moment. As I steadied it again, Hyuk Mujin kept shouting.

“Th-this! This!”

“What are you saying? I can’t hear you!”

The fierce snowstorm scattered sound and obscured my vision.

I was about to open my mouth again when a clear shout struck my ears.

“Above! Above!”

“Above?”

The fact that I could hear Hyuk Mujin’s voice meant the savage wind had paused. Only then did my obstructed vision clear and my ears open.

Following Hyuk Mujin’s gesture, I raised my head and finally saw it.

A massive boulder falling straight toward my face.

Whoooosh!

“Ah, shit.”

Boom!

[901] A tenth of a metric ton is 100 kg, about 220 lb.

"Wow. I can't believe you broke such a huge boulder with your bare fist."

I let Cheongpung's admiration go in one ear and out the other as I collapsed onto my back.

Only a moment ago, I had wanted nothing more than to beat that bastard senseless. Now I was completely drained.

I made it up. It's over!

Just as I lay there, unable to move even a hand and cheering inwardly, a bluish, frozen hand reached the summit.

"Huff. Haaah."

"You succeeded in only one day! You're both incredible!"

If it weren't for you, I would've made it in one shichen, you idiot.

I wanted to lay into him, but I was too exhausted to speak. As Hyuk Mujin and I panted with exhaustion and accomplishment, Cheongpung bowed deeply.

"Thank you both for your hard work! Now that you've succeeded once, you should be able to climb the remaining nine times much faster."

"..."

"..."

The words were so shocking that Hyuk Mujin and I forgot even to pant as we stared at him.

What is he talking about?

Could he possibly mean what I thought he meant?

No, surely not.

As an intellectual of modern society, I spoke with a calm demeanor.

"The remaining nine times? What kind of bullshit is that?"

"My grandfather..."

Was this bastard a wild man or a boy detective?

At that moment, Sword Saint or whatever be damned—I couldn't help seeing red.

"So you're telling us to do this nine more times?"

"Yes!"

"And you'll throw rocks at us from up here just the same?"

"Yes!"

"No."

"What?"

Hyuk Mujin and I dropped flat at the same time.

"I'm not doing it. I don't even have the strength to go back down. Go ahead and gut me."

“Gut me too, you vicious bastard!”

“Puhahaha.”

“…Are you laughing?”

Cheongpung smiled brightly.

“Sorry. You looked just like I did when I first started training, so I couldn’t help it.”

“See? You didn’t want to do it either!”

“No. I thought it was fun and wanted to keep going, but my body wouldn’t keep up.”

Hyuk Mujin muttered quietly enough that only I could hear.

“…Is he insane?”

“So I told my grandfather. I asked whether I could continue the next day because my legs wouldn’t listen to me.”

As he reminisced about his happy past, Cheongpung suddenly drew his sword.

At the same time, purple Sword Energy shot forth.

Shhk.

Ice, dirt, rock—Cheongpung cut through all of it without distinction, then continued speaking.

“My grandfather said climbing up was hard, but going down was easy. He said if I endured it for just a moment, I’d be back down in no time.”

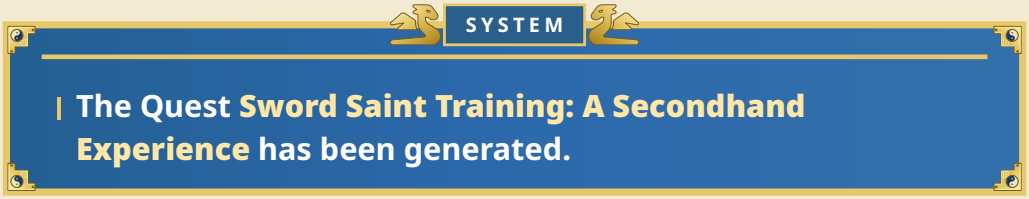
Rumble, rumble, rumble.

The edge of the cliff ledge where Hyuk Mujin and I were lying—barely ten square meters[902] in size—began to shake.

Is this for real?

As we lay there in a daze, Cheongpung waved at us.

“Nine more to go.”



[902] Ten square meters is about 108 ft².

Chapter 154

The middle-aged martial artist and Jang Childeuk were staring at the sky again today—or rather, at the cliff.

“Say, Brother Jang. Have you ever trained in the Wall Lizard Technique?”

“The Wall Lizard Technique? Good heavens, a coward like me would never dare. What about you, hyung[903]?”

“Once, about five years ago.”

“Why did you stop?”

“I’d been training for about three months when I lost my footing, fell, and broke my ankle.”

“Oof. You must have fallen from pretty high up.”

“Barely five jang[904] or so. I trained for three months without missing a single day, only to break my ankle.”

“That’s a shame.”

“A shame?”

“Who knows? If you’d kept at it, you might have become a master of the Wall Lizard Technique…”

“A master of the Wall Lizard Technique? Me? I’ve practiced sword techniques my entire life and still haven’t made it past Second Rate.”

The middle-aged martial artist let out a quiet laugh and pointed at the cliff.

“Whatever the martial art, you need talent to be called a master. Don’t you feel anything when you look at those two?”

“That’s certainly true.”

The two men watched the figures rapidly climbing the cliff.

There was no mistaking them. Jin Taekyung and Hyuk Mujin were dedicating themselves to Wall Lizard Technique training again today.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Stones and snowballs came tumbling down from far above.

At that very moment, both men were thinking the same thing.

Are those people or lizards?

Their hands and feet moved without hesitation as they scaled the nearly vertical cliff.

There was a considerable difference in their speed, but given how little time they had spent training, their progress was truly remarkable.

“How many days has it been?”

---

[903] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is familiar.

[904] Five *jang* is about 15.2 m, or 49.7 ft. A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to about 3.03 m.

"Let's see. This is our third shift, so… exactly three days."

"Only three days. If I'd trained for a year instead of three months, could I have learned the Wall Lizard Technique that well?"

"…"

Both the middle-aged martial artist and Jang Childeuk knew the answer.

After a brief silence, Childeuk spoke.

"Hyung[905]."

"Hmm?"

"What can people without martial talent do?"

"We're useless. Get out the jerky."

"Yes, sir."

Jang Childeuk promptly pulled some jerky and a bottle of liquor from his robes. He was quickly adapting to duty at the training hall, reputedly the cushiest assignment in the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Whoooosh!

I flattened myself against the cliff and dodged the boulder plummeting past at terrifying speed. Far above, Cheongpung smacked his lips in disappointment.

I knew you'd pull this, you bastard.

It wasn't like this was the first or second time he'd done it.

I might have been bad at studying as a kid, but when it came to learning with my body, I had been second to none.

"Haaaargh!"

Hyuk Mujin, on the other hand, was a little slower. Then again, there was a clear difference between his level and mine now, so perhaps that was only natural.

I shouted down at Hyuk Mujin, who was crawling up from far below.

"Mujin, you okay?"

"No!"

"…Oh. Right."

What a brutally quick answer.

Of course he wasn't okay, but most people would at least pretend they were. Hyuk Mujin didn't bother.

"Quit whining and get up here!"

"My whole body is cramping! I barely dodged that last one!"

For all his complaining, he was keeping up fairly well. This training had confirmed it once again: Hyuk Mujin had a fair amount of grit and martial talent.

[905] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is familiar.

“We’re almost there. Grit your teeth and climb!”

I wedged myself into a hollow in the cliff and took a moment to catch my breath.

Open the Quest window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest

Sword Saint Training: A Secondhand Experience

A master is forged through countless rounds of tempering and hammering.

Cheongpung, who received harsh training from the Sword Saint, will revive his childhood memories and put you through training!

Grade: Peak

Restriction: Those who have Cheongpung’s permission

Mission: Climb the cliff 10 times (9/10)

Reward: Acquire **Wall Lizard Technique**

Cheongpung is extremely pleased.

???

Failure: Injury or death

Cheongpung is extremely saddened.

Today marked exactly three days since we started climbing this damned cliff.

We had only one climb left before completing the Quest, but I still couldn’t let my guard down.

Because…

“Benefactor! Where are you? Poke your head out!”

“No! Get lost!”

“Oh, there you are! I ran out of things to throw nearby, so it took me a while to find more!”

Because of this psychopath who wanted to drop a boulder straight onto my face at any moment.

The first climb had been hard enough, but Cheongpung’s interference had grown more intense with every round.

I curled up as tightly as I could and shouted.

“Why would you go looking for more? If you run out of rocks, just stop throwing them!”

“But… if I don’t do this, you won’t be able to learn the Wall Lizard Technique properly, Benefactor!”

“…”

Was this guy insane?

How many people in the world learned the Wall Lizard Technique by getting pelted with boulders?

Just as I was rendered speechless by the sheer absurdity of it, a battered hand shot up into the hollow where I was hiding.

It wasn't the hand of some ghost who had died here long ago while training in the Wall Lizard Technique.

Naturally, it was Hyuk Mujin.

"Haaaargh. I'm dying."

When you were truly exhausted, you couldn't even speak. You got so out of breath that your head rang, and merely breathing made your chest ache.

Even so, Mujin still looked like he had plenty of life left in him. He crawled in beside me and spread his legs wide.

"Hey, it's cramped in here."

"You think you're the only one cramped, Captain? So am I."

"Pull your legs in or move over. This is basically a one-person seat."

"Ah, I'm exhausted. You move over, Captain. Aren't you being too harsh on your right-hand man after he worked so hard to get up here?"

"I treat my right arm well. But you're my little toe, so I can be a little harsh."

"Wow, you're really going to be like this? This is the only place we can hide from the rocks. Would you feel better if I jumped out and took one straight to the face?"

I answered with a perfectly serious expression.

"Why would you say that? Of course not."

"Oh, wow. What's gotten into you all of a sudden, Captain…"

"I'd feel stifled and guilty for a while. But after a year or so, I'd be fine. After ten years or so, I'd have forgotten your face."

"…That's awfully realistic."

"That's life, punk. Now pull your legs in before you give me something to feel guilty about."

"Yes, sir."

I didn't care if a manspreader got his skull cracked by a rock. That was what he got for manspreading.

Hyuk Mujin pulled his legs tightly together, caught his breath, and sighed.

"No matter how I think about it, this is insane."

"What is?"

"Cheongpung is insane for making us do this, and I'm insane for doing it just because he told me to."

"You're doing pretty well for someone who thinks it's insane."

"I'm just going at it like it's do or die."

“That’s the answer.”

“What?”

“Going at it like it’s do or die. That’s the answer. Later, when death really is staring you in the face, you’ll regret this moment.”

I tied back my disheveled hair and continued.

“Ah, I should’ve worked harder back then. You know, that kind of regret.”

I prided myself on having worked hard enough as a Hunter to practically shit blood. But even after all that, I was still left with regrets.

Regret always came too late. It only sank bone-deep after you had lost something precious.

“Your life, your wealth, or someone you care about. If you don’t want to lose something precious, put your life on the line now. Working yourself to death while you’re alive is still better than actually dying, isn’t it?”

“Uh…”

Hyuk Mujin stared at me with round eyes.

“You sound like you’re speaking from experience.”

“Why? Is that strange?”

“Words feel different depending on who says them. The Captain I know is, um…”

“Not exactly someone who should be saying that, having grown up as a young master who never wanted for anything?”

“If I had to put it that way, then yes. You look like someone who’s never lost anything precious in his life, but you talk like a battle-hardened veteran who’s been through every possible hardship.”

This guy had pretty good instincts.

Or maybe that was how I looked to everyone else, too.

I simply let out a quiet laugh without answering. Hyuk Mujin eyed me suspiciously.

“What’s with that laugh?”

“I was just thinking you’re pretty perceptive.”

“Captain, you’re not a fake, are you?”

“What?”

“It’s a little late to bring this up, but… you’ve changed too much. Your personality, your martial arts—everything. It’s like you’ve become a completely different person.”

“Haven’t you heard the rumors? I’m a secret weapon raised in secret by the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Rumors are just rumors. Unverified rumors. Plenty of people saw you carousing and wasting your days, Captain.”

“You were one of them?”

“Yes. At first, I thought you might be wearing a human-skin mask, but that doesn’t seem to be it.”

“A human-skin mask? The kind where you peel the skin off someone’s face and wear it?”

“See? You ask again as if you’re hearing about it for the first time. You also say things that make no sense all the time.”

“Hmm.”

Come to think of it, at some point I had stopped worrying so much about avoiding suspicion. Everyone around me thought I was Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I had also long since accepted my Murim self as part of who I was.

“If you’re some kind of double put forward by a shadowy organization like the ones in novels, tell me now. I’ll quietly let it slide.”

“What an absurd thing to say. Then you should report me immediately.”

“Well, I like you much better now than before. And I owe you my life. Hehe.”

His lips were smiling, but he wasn’t joking. The subtle bob of his throat and the slight tremor in his eyes proved it.

I thought for a moment, then spoke.

“Want me to tell you honestly?”

“H-honestly?”

“I’ve been itching to tell someone anyway, so this works out. The location is perfect, too.”

Hyuk Mujin glanced around anxiously.

The hollow in the cliff was just large enough for two people to plant their backsides. As luck would have it, the lunatic who would drop a rock on us the moment we stuck our faces outside was waiting nearby, too.

It was the perfect spot for two people to sit together until one of them died, with no one the wiser.

“You really are stupid, aren’t you?”

Hyuk Mujin swallowed hard.

“C-C-Captain. I don’t care who you are.”

“Too late.”

“Gasp! I won’t say anything! I meant what I said earlier!”

“Even if I belonged to the Demonic Cult?”

“The Demonic Cult!”

“I’m only going to say this once. Listen carefully.”

“I’ll pretend I didn’t hear it. No, I won’t listen!”

Hyuk Mujin’s face turned deathly pale as he tried to cover his ears, but my words came a moment faster.

“I’m actually from another world.”

"…?"

"People can talk to each other even when they're ten thousand li[906] apart, and monsters with horns or wings roam everywhere. If you put it in Murim terms, I suppose you'd call them Fiends."

"…What?"

"Anyway, somehow I ended up here from that kind of world. Then strange things started appearing before my eyes, and suddenly—Level Up! Bam! Points! Boom! Ding-ding-ding inside my head!"

"…"

"Anyway, I only entered the world of martial arts two or three months ago. I've wiped the floor with dozens of First Rate masters and taken down three Peak masters. So, any questions?"

Hyuk Mujin slowly lowered the hands that had been half-covering his ears.

His expression was a complicated mixture of irritation and relief.

"Whew. Let's just say I was wrong. Happy now?"

"Why? It's true. You don't believe me?"

"Not even a stray dog would believe that. If only my martial arts were stronger…"

Smack!

I smacked him on the back of the head, then stood up.

It was a true story, but it didn't sound true.

Of course, I had expected Hyuk Mujin to react this way. That was precisely why I had told him.

Someone coming from another world? Anyone would think it was ridiculous.

"Nevel-up? Poin-two? Good grief. I should've kept my mouth shut. I don't know what I expected from you, Captain."

"What did you expect? The Demonic Cult? The Blood Cult?"

"Oh, come on! Just stop!"

I grabbed Hyuk Mujin by the shoulder as he stood up. The next instant, a boulder as tall as a grown man shot past us with a murderous shriek of displaced air.

"Watch yourself. We still have a long way to go."

I patted him on the back and resumed climbing.

We were only halfway to the summit.

The moment Hyuk Mujin and I finally reached the summit, System notifications erupted like celebratory cannon fire.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

[906] Ten thousand Chinese *li* is about 5,000 km, or 3,110 mi. One Chinese *li* is about 500 m.

SYSTEM

Cliff climb: 10 times (10/10)
Quest successfully completed!
New martial art, Wall Lizard Technique, is now activated!
You have achieved outstanding results beyond expectations. An additional Reward will be granted!
Level Up!
You have acquired 10 Stat Points and 10 Skill Points!
The Title Novice Trainee has been upgraded to Intermediate Trainee!
Open the relevant System window to check and apply the changes.

Cheongpung beamed at us.

“Wow! You really did it!”

“…What’s that supposed to mean?”

“By any chance—”

This bastard. Don’t tell me…

At the sharp looks we gave him, Cheongpung shook his head.

“It’s nothing. It took me fifteen days, you see. I didn’t expect you to finish so quickly.”

“Fifteen days?”

Hyuk Mujin repeated the number, then stared at me in disbelief.

Who was Cheongpung? The Sword Saint’s successor and a Peak master who had defeated Jin Mukyung. Mujin must have found it hard to believe that we had achieved this faster than he had.

But…

“What are you so happy about, punk? We’re not the same age. Right?”

“I wasn’t even that young! I was already ten years old!”

“…Isn’t ten usually considered young?”

Cheongpung smiled brightly as he reminisced about those days.

“Back then, climbing up Falling Goose Peak and falling back down was part of my daily routine. It was so much fun.”

“Falling Goose Peak?”

“It’s a peak on Huashan. It’s easily more than five hundred jang[907] high. Oh, of course, I couldn’t make it all the way to the top until I was eighteen.”

“…”

[907] Five hundred *jang* is about 1,515 m, or 4,970 ft.

"…"

Wasn't ten too young even to watch a movie rated fifteen-plus?

At that age, he would've only been in third grade—barely old enough to count as a snot-nosed schoolkid.

When I was that age, I played on the jungle gym in the schoolyard…

That bastard Cheongpung had played on the peaks of Huashan.

As expected of the continent. Everything was on a different scale.

"Anyway, thank you both so, so much for your hard work. You achieved something amazing!"

Cheongpung clapped excitedly all by himself, then continued.

"So, about that…"

Sensing something ominous, Hyuk Mujin hurriedly cut in.

"No. Hold on. Wait just a second."

"I know lots of even more fun training exercises."

"Hey! I said wait a second!"

Hyuk Mujin lunged at him with a shout, but it was already too late. Cheongpung effortlessly subdued him with a grappling technique and called out energetically,

"Let's all give it our best!"

Ding.

SYSTEM

Cheongpung is in extremely high spirits over your outstanding achievement!

As a special Reward, the linked Quest Sword Saint Training: A Secondhand Experience—2 has been generated!

"You bastard! Let go of my arm right now!"

As I listened to Hyuk Mujin shout, a question suddenly occurred to me.

How many linked Quests are there?

One thing was certain.

There was no way Cheongpung would stop at a measly two.

He's going to work us into the ground.

Leaving Hyuk Mujin's squawking behind me, I looked up at the sky.

The vast sky was a brilliant blue. The air was cool, and several hawks drifted overhead with their enormous wings spread wide.

New Year's Day was ten days away.

Chapter 155

A silent room. Six or seven scholars were frantically immersed in their work.

With haggard faces, they processed the bamboo slips piled up like mountains one by one while reporting various matters to the master of the office.

“There’s been a dispute between the Yellow River Gang and the Sogong Sect. They’ve asked our family to mediate…”

“Tell them we’ll set aside time on New Year’s Day to discuss it. Inform the Inner Hall Master in advance.”

“What should we do about the matter concerning the Five Gates of Shanxi?”

“Ah, is this related to the third one?”

“Yes. The hall masters of the Five Gates of Shanxi are waiting to offer their apologies.”

“Send them back. If they were truly sorry, the heads themselves should have come in person instead of sending their hands and feet. Inform the Inner Hall Master of that, too.”

“Next, there’s a matter from the Southern Merchant Guild…”

Even as he received their reports, Jin Wikyung, the master of the office, never looked up from the bamboo slips.

But the next report made even him raise his head.

“Lesser Family Head, mounted-bandit groups from the northern plateau are showing suspicious movements near Datong.”

“Mounted bandits? Is this information from the Lower District Sect?”

“Yes. If left unchecked, they’ll launch a large-scale raid against the common people.”

“How large is their force?”

“Five mounted-bandit groups have formed an alliance. Around five hundred men are gradually gathering.”

“Mounted bandits, huh? They’ve been a constant nuisance.”

Jin Wikyung rubbed between his brows, his face weary.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was undeniably powerful, but it still lacked the strength to cover all of Shanxi Province.

That was also why the mounted bandits kept watching for an opportunity despite knowing that the Red Wind Band had been annihilated.

“Should we draft some martial artists?”

At the scholar’s question, Jin Wikyung immediately shook his head.

“No.”

“We’ve had more martial artists join our family recently than we can count. We have men to spare.”

“We’ve already shed too much blood for that. Besides, those we accepted this time still lack experience. Even if we recruit several hundred, several hundred will die.”

The Mount Heng Sword Sect.

One of the legs supporting the tripod of Shanxi Province had broken, and the water inside was beginning to spill over.

They had to devise a countermeasure before the boiling water scalded them.

After a moment’s thought, Jin Wikyung spoke.

“For the time being, focus on establishing and stabilizing branches in each prefecture and county. That is our top priority.”

“Lesser Family Head!”

The scholar cried out in surprise. The others, who had been focused on their own tasks, also raised their heads.

Hundreds of mounted bandits were supposedly invading, and yet establishing branches was the top priority. Did that mean they did not care whether the common people died?

As disappointment spread across the scholars’ faces, Jin Wikyung continued.

“Instead, ask the Five Gates of Shanxi for support. Two hundred men should be about right… What do you think?”

“That won’t be nearly enough.”

There was no one in this office, at least, who could speak so bluntly to the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Jin Wikyung grinned at Wipeng as he came through the door.

“Is that so? I thought it would be enough.”

“What sort of people are the Five Gates of Shanxi now? They’re obsessed with clawing at one another for scraps. They’ll hide their carefully trained elites inside their walls and send us a force packed with clueless Second Rate and Third Rate martial artists.”

“That sounds plausible.”

“It’s not just plausible. That’s what will happen nine times out of ten. The mounted bandits will see all those peach-fuzzed little punks and be so delighted their mouths will split open.”

“Haha. So we have to step in?”

“What choice do we have? If you attach some useful men to the force, I’ll go there myself. Then the Five Gates of Shanxi won’t be able to pull any sneaky tricks.”

“Exactly. Isn’t the Ghost Sword more frightening than a ghost?”

At Jin Wikyung’s teasing tone, Wipeng shook his head from side to side.

“That’s enough. Tell me.”

“Tell you what?”

“You already have a plan, don’t you?”

“What plan? Your idea sounded good to me.”

“Good grief. Since when have you listened so closely to anything I say?”

“Every word from your mouth is a golden rule to me.”

Wipeng let out a deep sigh and turned toward the scholar standing blankly nearby.

“What do you think?”

“P-pardon?”

A thin frame and a pale, washed-out face. He was the very picture of a pale-faced scholar who did nothing but pore over books in his room.

At Wipeng’s sudden question, he stammered out an answer.

“I-I don’t think it will be enough.”

“Is that all?”

“We should draft more men…”

Watching him, Jin Wikyung cut in with a laugh.

“That’s enough. And you.”

Already cowed by Wipeng’s sharp aura, the scholar flinched.

“Yes.”

“Send word to the Five Gates of Shanxi and the Shanxi Provincial Office. Tell them mounted bandits are swarming near Datong and that we request their assistance.”

“The Shanxi Provincial Office?”

“The people are in danger. The government ought to roll up its sleeves and help. Ah, casually give the Five Gates of Shanxi a hint about it, too.”

“Judging by the government’s passive attitude over the past several years, the chances of that succeeding are slim.”

“Then make it succeed.”

Jin Wikyung’s face lost its smile as he added one more thing.

“Isn’t that your job?”

“Ah.”

The scholar’s mind snapped awake. He was exhausted from staying up several nights, but he had been thinking far too simply.

Request help from Shanxi Province? The countermeasure proposed by Wipeng, a man who was a martial artist down to his bones, was much more plausible.

“I apologize.”

“You’re still inexperienced, so I understand. But what our family needs isn’t scholars. We need wise men who can offer the best possible measures for the sake of our family. I hope you’ll remember that.”

There was nothing the scholar could say. Seeing that not only the man before him but everyone else had reddened faces, Jin Wikyung spoke again.

“You’re all tired, so go in and rest for today.”

No one would refuse an order to rest, least of all men who had spent the last three days surviving on brief naps with bamboo slips for pillows.

Once the scholars dragged their exhausted bodies out, Wipeng pulled over an empty chair.

“Are those the new recruits?”

“Being on my own was too much. Still, they’re better than nothing.”

“I’m not sure. They all seem rather bland.”

“How many of them studied in order to join our family? It’s only natural.”

Jin Wikyung stretched his arms high. The loud cracking of bones echoed through the room.

“It’s only been a few days. We need to separate the jade from the stones and send away those who need to go.”

“Is that also why you didn’t tell them about the secret agreement with the Shanxi Provincial Office?”

“Why is a secret agreement called a secret agreement? The fewer people who know about it, the better.”

In truth, securing the assistance of the Shanxi Provincial Office was not particularly difficult. Hadn’t he and Deputy Military Commissioner Hong Jin already exchanged plenty through their conversation five days earlier?

“Our family hasn’t fully established itself yet. It would be troublesome if rumors spread that we had entered into a secret agreement with the government under these circumstances.”

“True. Especially when the rumors happen to be facts.”

The conversation Jin Wikyung had exchanged with Hong Jin had included several topics that the small and medium-sized sects of Shanxi Province—and especially the Five Gates of Shanxi—would not welcome.

If the Seongun Escort Bureau heard what Jin Wikyung and Hong Jin had discussed, they might collapse frothing at the mouth.

“So, are the other preparations going well?”

“Yes. I’ve completed the personnel changes as you ordered. The heads of the Inner and Outer Halls have been left in place, and we’ve established three new squads…”

The report flowing from Wipeng’s mouth concerned the first matter Jin Wikyung had handled immediately after the war ended.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was like a rising sun. To the hot-blooded young people of Shanxi Province, it was the finest choice available.

To embrace the endless stream of people coming to them, the family had to widen its arms even further.

"…That's how I handled it, but with our numbers expected to keep growing, we'll likely need to reorganize again later."

"That's what we should hope for."

Jin Wikyung tried to appear calm as he listened to Wipeng's report.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had declined slowly but steadily since the Great Faction War. Now, however, it was rapidly regaining its former glory.

No. Perhaps it will become even stronger than it was before the Great Faction War.

If that happened…

Only then would they truly earn the right to be called a great family.

They would break free of their status as a frontier martial family and stand shoulder to shoulder with the towering powers of the realm.

A great family. A great family, huh.

It was a word that made his heart race just to think about it.

Just as every martial artist dreamed of becoming the Martial God, Jin Wikyung had long dreamed of raising his family onto the foundation of a great family.

New Year's Day is almost here.

On that day, before all the sects of Shanxi Murim, the Jin Family of Taiyuan would be recognized as the undisputed hegemon of Shanxi Province.

Jin Wikyung had no doubt that the first day of the coming year would become the Jin Family of Taiyuan's first stepping-stone—and the harbinger of its rise—as a great family.

And it was at the very moment he secretly clenched his fist that—

"Um… May I come in?"

"Hm? Of course."

The voice belonged to the scholar who had just left.

"What is it? Did you leave something behind?"

"It's not that…"

Under Jin Wikyung and Wipeng's puzzled gazes, the scholar continued cautiously.

"There's some news I failed to report."

"You're too conscientious for your own good. You've been working hard for days without even getting proper sleep. Don't worry about it. Go in and get some rest."

"No. I should have told you earlier, but it slipped my mind…"

"Now, now. It's fine. I told you to rest."

Wipeng chimed in.

"My lord is right. You aren't a jiangshi.[908] You need to get enough rest so you can have the strength to work again tomorrow…"

"Huashan has sent the Three Plum Blossom Elites."

[908] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse in Chinese folklore.

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng shot to their feet at the same time.

“What!”

“What did you say?”

Who were the Three Plum Blossom Elites?

They were the most exceptional talents among the Plum Blossom Swordsmen, Huashan’s finest.

In particular, Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong, was a major figure expected to become the next Sect Leader and carry Huashan’s future upon his shoulders.

After hearing such news, how could the two men’s eyes not nearly pop from their sockets?

“Is that really true?”

“Yes. I meant to tell you at the end, but I forgot. And there’s one more thing.”

“One more?”

“Another? Tell us quickly!”

The visit of the Three Plum Blossom Elites was shocking enough, and now he was saying there was something else.

Frowning, the scholar continued.

“They say the Grandmaster has disappeared. He seems to have gone to our family, so they asked us to send word if we happen to meet him… But who is the Grandmaster?”

The scholar was still unfamiliar with the realities of Murim and wondered what this was all about. Jin Wikyung and Wipeng, however, stood with their mouths hanging open.

“If Huashan’s Grandmaster is…”

“Th-th-that…”

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

Unable to bring themselves to say the name aloud, the two men merely mouthed the words and swallowed hard.

Huashan still wanted to keep the Sword Saint’s whereabouts secret. At times like this, it was best to keep one’s mouth shut.

“Th-that… What did you say?”

“Th-that thing. You know, that sort of thing.”

“Pardon?”

“You can leave now. Erase everything that just happened from your mind. Understood?”

The scholar bowed with a bewildered expression and left. Only then did the words they had been holding back burst out.

“The Sword Saint is coming!”

“Shh! Lower your voice. We don’t even know for certain yet.”

Despite his words, Wipeng's face had also flushed bright red. To a swordsman like him, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was greater than even the Jade Emperor.[909]

To think they might be able to meet such a person in the flesh! No, perhaps he might even receive instruction from him.

"B-but why would the Sword Saint come to our family?"

"What else could it be?"

"Ah."

He had been so excited that he had momentarily forgotten who was currently staying at the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

"That Sword Saint broke his seclusion to look for his beloved disciple."

"It's only a guess for now, but that's highly likely. I hear he raised him like his own grandson. How deep must his affection be?"

Jin Wikyung grinned broadly.

Whatever the reason, the Sword Saint's visit was something to welcome with open arms—not only as a martial artist, but also as the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

"You said his name was Cheongpung, right? Where is he now? I seem to remember hearing a while ago that he was training my youngest brother in the Wall Lizard Technique.[910]"

"The Wall Lizard Technique[911] training ended two days ago, and now he's…"

"And now?"

"He's beating the crap out of the Third Young Master."

"Whaaat!"

[909]The Jade Emperor is a ruler of the heavens in Daoist tradition.
[910]The Wall Lizard Technique is a martial art used to climb walls and cliffs.
[911]The Wall Lizard Technique is a martial art used to climb walls and cliffs.

Chapter 156

Thud!

Timing, speed, strength. And finally, even the point of impact.

That blow had landed perfectly. There was just one unfortunate fact: that perfect blow had buried itself in my solar plexus.

“Guh!”

In an instant, excruciating pain robbed me of my breath. Through my blurred vision, I saw Cheongpung raising his fist.

“W-wait!”

“Why?”

“You hit me in the solar plexus. My solar plexus.”

“Grandfather said that once a fight begins, you have to beat your opponent to a pulp.”

“This is a spar!”

“Grandfather also said you have to treat spars like real battles if you want to survive in the harsh martial world.”

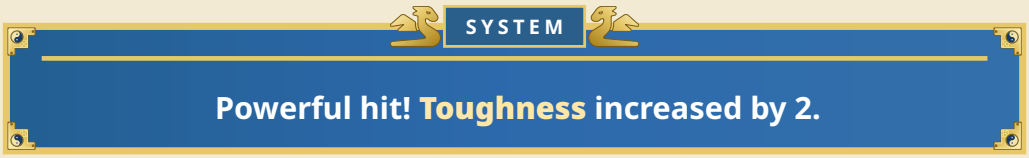
I had nothing to say to that. This wasn’t some old man who ran the neighborhood supermarket. The Sword Saint had taught him that. What could I possibly say? Besides, treating every fight like a real battle wasn’t exactly bad advice.

Once I gave up on everything, I felt at peace.

“…Fine, fuck it. Hit me.”

“Yes!”

Smack!



My vision flashed white, and my legs gave out. My body slowly toppled backward against my will.

Can’t crack the back of my head.

Fortunately, what I feared didn’t happen. Hyuk Mujin had already passed out and fallen over, and his butt cushioned the back of my head.

It’s filthy. Filthy, but soft. Filthy, but firm.

This bastard had an apple-shaped ass, minimum.

It was enough to make me wonder whether he’d been doing Pilates or yoga between shifts at the Gate Guard Pavilion.

Using Hyuk Mujin's butt as a pillow, I looked up at the sky. Maybe it was because I was seeing it after getting beaten senseless, but the sky looked yellow.

Check Quest.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Sword Saint Training: A Secondhand Experience—2
Cheongpung, exhilarated by your outstanding results, has presented a second training challenge.
Knock him down at least once before New Year's Day!
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Those who have completed the prerequisite Quest
Mission: Win the duel against Cheongpung (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Cheongpung is very pleased.
Failure: ???
Cheongpung is very saddened.

The thought that I would win at least once had vanished the moment the spar began.

My duel with Cheongpung was even more one-sided than my duel with Jin Mukyung, and that much more brutal.

How does he know so many martial arts?

I had seen more than a dozen different martial arts over the past two days alone.

Just when I thought I might be getting used to the Taeeul Miri Palm, he would bring out the Falling Flower Chasing Shadow Palm. Just as that technique began to look familiar, the Crouching Tiger Fist would come flying out.

On top of that, countless supreme techniques that had helped turn Huashan into one of the Nine Sects and One Gang[912] had seeped into every part of Cheongpung's body.

His martial arts are rooted in Huashan. His teacher was the Sword Saint.

Didn't this guy need a balance patch?

"Heh heh. Hehehehe."

As I let out nothing but hollow laughter, Cheongpung approached and asked,

"Benefactor, are you all right?"

"If you're going to ask that, you could at least go easy on me."

[912] A conventional grouping of major orthodox martial factions in martial-arts fiction.

“But then it wouldn’t be training. Doing something half-heartedly is worse than not doing it at all…”

“Your grandfather said that, didn’t he?”

“Gasp! How did you know? Have you ever lived on Lotus Peak?”

“…No.”

I was born and raised in Gyeonggi Province, you punk.

I heaved a sigh and pulled myself upright. Hyuk Mujin, who had been unconscious for quite some time, still hadn’t moved an inch.

“What did you do to him? Isn’t he going to die at this rate?”

“I did try to control my strength, but I guess I was a little inexperienced.”

“Control your strength?”

“Yes. I’ve only ever had one sparring partner in my entire life.”

Cheongpung had spent his life sparring daily with the Sword Saint, a Supreme Peak master, as casually as if they were sharing meals. Naturally, he would only have learned how to go all out.

He continued with sad eyes.

“Now that I’m out in the world, it’s much harder than I expected. I was so clumsy that I injured the Senior from the Zhongnan Sect, and now even Warrior Hyuk…”

It seemed this mountain hermit was having a rough time adjusting to Murim.

I scratched the back of my head.

“Don’t worry about that. The Zhongnan guy was someone who deserved to get hit, and Mujin won’t take it to heart. It’s training, after all.”

“Really?”

“Yes. You’re getting better and better, so don’t worry too much.”

Cheongpung smiled brightly, as though none of that had ever happened.

“Benefactor, did you know?”

“How would I know?”

“Of all the people I’ve met in Murim, I like you best, Benefactor!”

I drew up my internal energy.

“Back off right now. If you lay so much as a fingertip on me, I’ll bite my tongue and die.”

“Because even if I hit you with all my strength, you always get back up!”

“Oh.”

“And you’re the most satisfying to hit!”

Listen to the way he said that.

Relief and irritation surged through me at the same time. I had wondered why he seemed to be beating me so enthusiastically. Without realizing it, I had become a sandbag for testing punching power.

No wonder my Toughness kept shooting up.

Toughness was the last stat I'd acquired, and I'd barely invested anything in it. Even so, it had already caught up with the combat stats I'd poured points into.

Should I be grateful for this?

It had only been a few days of short-term training, but I was certainly seeing substantial results.

Scaling the cliff had earned me the Wall Lizard Technique and a considerable boost to my stats. Now I was experiencing Huashan's martial arts firsthand while raising my Toughness like crazy.

"Please continue to take good care of me. I'm learning a lot by hitting you, Benefactor."

"…Ah. Yes."

I wanted to smack Cheongpung on the back of the head as he bowed politely, but I held myself back. I knew there was no real malice behind anything he said.

Part of me was relieved, too.

If he were any stronger than this, I'd be completely screwed.

Cheongpung was a mountain I absolutely had to climb.

If he'd been holding back even while facing me, I would've found that more insulting than anything else.

Consideration from someone you wanted to defeat never felt like consideration.

I spoke in a solemn voice.

"Let me ask you one thing."

"Anything, Benefactor."

"When you fight me, give it everything you've got."

"Everything I've got?"

"Yes. Your best. That's all I need."

Cheongpung stared at me for a moment, then nodded.

"Understood."

"Thank you—"

Ssssss.

Before I could finish speaking, the heat of the Zaha Divine Technique blazed up from Cheongpung's entire body like a wildfire, burning through the cold winter air.

His eyes, already tinged with a faint violet hue, fixed on me.

"I'll really give it my best, Benefactor."

"…Oh. So this is your best?"

Damn it. I'd forgotten about that.

At my vacant stare, Cheongpung smacked his forehead.

"Oh, right. I'm sorry. I can be a little slow on the uptake."

"It's all right. As long as you understood me eventually, that's—"

Shing.

This time, Sword Energy rose in a long, surging blade from the sword in Cheongpung's hand.

"Now I'm ready to give it my best."

"Ah…"

"Benefactor, I'll really work hard! Even if I fight you with all my strength, you're bound to get back up anyway!"

I wasn't so sure. I had a feeling I wouldn't be getting back up this time.

I silently stared at the undulating energy of the Zaha Divine Technique and the blazing Sword Energy before finally managing to speak.

"L-let's put away the Sword Energy."

Let me live too, you bastard.

Whoosh!

The spearhead tore through the air. A fast, razor-sharp strike. Cheongpung rolled his shoulder aside, and the second and third attacks followed like a storm.

"Hah!"

With a shout, spearheads rained down. The martial art itself was simple and heavy.

But the movements of the man wielding the spear were light and fast. Hidden between his efficient movements were unpredictable attacks.

Swish! Swish-swish-swish!

A smile tugged at Cheongpung's lips as he narrowly evaded the spearhead.

Wow, this is fun. Was Benefactor always this good?

He beamed as he watched the young man pressing him relentlessly.

Jin Taekyung. They hadn't known each other long, but he was the Benefactor who had helped Cheongpung in many ways.

When Jin Taekyung had given him every last candied hawthorn skewer[913] at their first meeting, Cheongpung had nearly cried.

He's a good person. He gave me something so precious.

Grandfather had been wrong. He had said Murim was crawling with frightening people who were vicious and utterly ruthless, but everyone Cheongpung had met was gentle and kind-hearted.

[913] Traditional fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

He didn't even dislike the Senior from the Zhongnan Sect whom he'd injured through his own mistake not long ago.

He's my Senior, so he can't be a bad person.

As far as Cheongpung knew, the bond between Seniors and Juniors was no ordinary relationship. It was a close tie forged by something thicker than blood.

And Grandfather had always told him to protect the weak.

The Senior from the Zhongnan Sect had been weak in martial arts. Cheongpung had felt terrible for hurting him.

But…

It was nice that there was no reason to feel bad about Jin Mukyung and Jin Taekyung.

They were the strongest people Cheongpung had met since leaving Huashan. Even now, as he exchanged blows with Jin Taekyung, he was enjoying himself immensely.

Whoosh!

Cheongpung easily dodged the spear thrusting toward his shoulder, then burst out laughing despite himself.

"Hehe."

"You laughing?"

"Because I'm happy."

"You really need to watch what you say. That's a dangerous thing to say."

Swish-swish-swish!

Six killing attacks and twice as many feints came raining down from every direction. But Cheongpung was no longer where he had been.

Jin Taekyung pierced the faint afterimage and shouted with the expression of someone who had seen a ghost.

"What the hell was that?"

"Dark Fragrance Drift. Hehe."

"That's cheating!"

"Would you like me to teach you?"

"Great Hero Cheongpung, as for me, I've been barely scraping by in this harsh world with the paltry Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique…"

"Oh, right. Grandfather told me not to teach it to anyone."

"This little bastard?"

Whoosh!

Jin Taekyung changed direction and thrust low.

Just before the fiercely spinning spearhead pierced his instep, Cheongpung raised his foot with dazzling speed and pressed the spearhead down toward the ground instead.

Scrape!

"Wow, that was a little dangerous."

But Jin Taekyung wasn't listening to him. With a short shout, he lifted the spear shaft beneath Cheongpung's foot.

"Hah!"

"Benefactor, it's no use. This is the Thousand-Catty Drop[914]—"

Whoosh!

The next moment, Cheongpung felt himself floating.

Jin Taekyung's tremendous strength whipped the spear shaft skyward, flinging Cheongpung's feet clear and leaving them treading empty air.

He lost his balance for an instant and hurriedly drew up his internal energy.

Boom! Boom! Swish-swish!

The force of the Falling Flower Chasing Shadow Palm struck the air and shoved his body backward. A split second later, Jin Taekyung's spear stabbed and slashed through the space where Cheongpung had been.

Wow.

Jin Taekyung's strength was beyond Cheongpung's imagination, even if it was still inferior to his grandfather's.

No. It wasn't just his strength.

He had incredible stamina, enough to fall countless times and keep getting back up. Agility that shouldn't have been possible for someone with his build. And tremendous Toughness.

Even the way he uses martial arts is different from everyone else.

Cheongpung was a Peak master. He had been raised by the Sword Saint and had grown up watching the Sword Saint's martial arts.

He could gauge an opponent's level from a single move and half a form of the martial arts they displayed.

Jin Mukyung was sharp.

Jin Mukyung, whom he'd dueled a few days earlier, possessed an aura that seemed sharp enough to cut anyone who touched it. His martial arts were the same.

But despite sharing the same blood, Jin Taekyung's disposition and martial arts were the exact opposite of his brother's.

What should I call this?

Though his martial arts were rough, still unrefined, and otherwise unremarkable, his movements created a strange tension. His aura seeped out naturally…

"Whew. You coming? If not, I'm coming to you."

[914] A catty, or Chinese *jin*, is 500 g (1.10 lb). The technique's name evokes immense downward weight.

At the sight of the man striding toward him, Cheongpung finally thought of a word.

Wildness.

A beast hell-bent on biting through its prey’s throat.

Jin Taekyung’s claws had not yet been honed, and that was precisely why they seemed even larger.

Chapter 157

Since ancient times, it had been said that the masters of famous mountains were spirit creatures. Huashan, one of the Five Sacred Mountains of the Central Plains, was no exception.

Before humans ever set foot there, tigers had ruled its lofty, sprawling forests.

These spirit creatures possessed the majesty of kings and the ferocity of beasts. When their territory was invaded, they grew furious and soon began attacking the uninvited trespassers.

“Wow! And then?”

“When the loss of human life became severe, the Huashan Sect had no choice but to step in. That was how the Crouching Tiger Fist was born.”

A fist technique that subdues tigers. The Crouching Tiger Fist.

Cheongpung clearly remembered what his grandfather had told him when he learned the Crouching Tiger Fist long ago.

“Pung, the Crouching Tiger Fist is a powerful martial art capable of subduing the king of the mountains. Master this one technique, and no one your age will be able to stand against you. Do you understand?”

“Yes!”

As a child, Cheongpung had believed his grandfather’s words without question.

But now, ten years later—

Whack!

“Ow, that hurt.”

“…Huh?”

For the first time, he realized that even his grandfather could be wrong.

It was the third day since I’d begun sparring with Cheongpung. During our forty-fifth duel, I witnessed him stumble over his words for the first time.

“B-Benefactor, are you all right?”

“I know. That was the Crouching Tiger Fist, right?”

I’d seen it with my own eyes and even experienced it firsthand by getting hit.

It was yesterday that a Crouching Tiger Fist to the solar plexus had laid me out flat.

I’d committed the way Cheongpung moved when he used the Crouching Tiger Fist to memory—the footwork, the position of his shoulders, even the sequence of forms that followed.

And yet I had still allowed myself to be hit.

There was no doubt about it. Cheongpung was one step ahead of me.

“What was the name of that form just now?”

Cheongpung answered with a dazed expression.

“One Fist Subdues the Tiger.”

A single fist that brought down a tiger? It certainly packed enough destructive power to justify the name. If my ability to take a hit hadn’t improved with every duel, I would have dropped to my knees just like yesterday.

Should I take comfort in doing much better than yesterday?

And it wasn’t only my ability to take a hit that had improved. After experiencing Cheongpung’s martial arts firsthand, I was gradually getting used to them.

“All right, let’s go again.”

But Cheongpung didn’t seem interested in continuing.

“How did you dodge it?”

“Huh?”

“I was aiming precisely around your Fengwei acupoint…”

The Fengwei acupoint was around the ribs. I’d twisted aside to dodge, only to take the blow square in the middle of my abdomen.

Since I’d avoided his intended target, maybe that technically counted as dodging? I shrugged.

“I just struggled to avoid getting hit even once. I got hit in the end, though.”

“Could you see the sequence of forms?”

After being beaten up for several days, I could make out the forms vaguely. Where and how an attack would come from. How the next form would follow.

The problem is that I’m still clumsy.

I rubbed my aching abdomen as I answered.

“After taking this many hits, I should be able to read at least that much. Every time you hit me, I made sure to keep my eyes wide open and watch.”

Wasn’t keeping your eyes open even while getting hit and figuring out your opponent’s sequence of forms the most basic thing?

“Huh. That’s strange. I’ve only used the Crouching Tiger Fist a few times.”

“That’s why it took me a little longer to figure out than the others.”

“The others?”

“Yeah. The Plum Blossom Fist was pretty easy. Maybe it’s because you used it the most during our duels, but I more or less figured it out.”

Cheongpung clapped in admiration.

“Wow! Can you show me?”

“It’s nothing difficult.”

I performed a poor imitation of the Plum Blossom Fist. My footwork and movements were both terribly awkward, but every form came from the Plum Blossom Fist Cheongpung had used in our duels.

This much is easy.

At some point after I began learning martial arts, I'd realized something.

Executing a technique required an understanding of the martial art and the internal-energy control to match. But merely copying its shape was easy.

I moved like this here, didn't I? Probably?

From the first form to the seventh. I occasionally stumbled, but I managed to perform them as naturally as possible without much difficulty. Then I turned my head.

"That's about it for now… Cheongpung?"

"Ah, yes, Benefactor."

"Is something wrong? Why do you look like that?"

"No, it's just…"

Cheongpung stared at me with an oddly complicated expression before hesitantly opening his mouth.

"I suddenly remembered something my grandfather once said."

"The Sword Saint old man—I mean, your grandfather?"

"Yes. He used to call me a thief."

"It's all right. When I was young, I secretly took a thousand won[915] from my mother's wallet and got beaten half to death."

"That's not what I mean…"

Cheongpung let out a deep sigh.

"He always said it while teaching me martial arts. He called me a thief who stole martial arts."

"Oh."

That was a compliment, right? To think a talent freak like Cheongpung was praising me.

As I stood there dumbfounded, Cheongpung said, "Benefactor, you're definitely a martial-arts genius."

"A genius? Me?"

"Yes."

A genius, my ass…

No, wait. He was right.

When I thought about it, I had mastered the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique and spear technique—both First Rate martial arts—in barely two or three months.

Of course, that was all thanks to the System.

"It's just a shortcut. I'm pretty good at using my body. My eyes are good, too. Heh heh."

[915] A thousand Korean won is about $0.71 or €0.65.

“My grandfather used to say that martial arts are seventy percent eyes and thirty percent feet.”

“I think he was right about that, but either way, I’m not a genius.”

“Think about it carefully. I’m sure something similar happened before.”

Was that so?

I suddenly remembered my childhood. I’d always been good at sports thanks to my natural athletic ability, but as for anything that could be called martial arts…

Oh. There was one.

When my expression changed, Cheongpung nodded as if to say, *See?*

“Something did happen, didn’t it?”

“There was one. Taekwondo.”

“Taekwondo?”

“It’s something like a martial art.”

Back in elementary school, I’d been lured into enrolling at a taekwondo academy with the promise of a portable game console.

The older high school students had put on a taekwondo demonstration, and after watching it exactly twice, I could follow all eight Taegeuk forms.[916]

Of course, less than a week later, I beat up a middle schooler two years older than me and got kicked out.

Could that have been it?

Come to think of it, even when I was an F-rank Hunter, I’d been pretty good at copying almost anything.

My lousy physical abilities had simply held me back.

If a bottom-tier Hunter like me tried to imitate the movements of a mid-rank Hunter, I wouldn’t be able to generate any destructive power. I’d just tear my groin apart.

But things are different now.

Overflowing internal energy. Excellent physical abilities. And martial arts learned in Murim.

Now that I thought about it, I might not be a martial-arts genius, but I did seem to have a fair amount of talent.

“How long did it take you to learn the Plum Blossom Fist, Cheongpung?”

“One month.”

“One month?”

From my own experience, the Plum Blossom Fist was a Huashan martial art, but it wasn’t complicated enough to take that long.

[916] The Taegeuk forms are a standardized sequence of eight color-belt patterns in taekwondo.

And this guy had needed a month to learn it, while I'd managed a rough imitation in three days?

That's insane.

As I grinned so broadly that the corners of my mouth nearly split, Cheongpung added, "It took me a whole month to achieve Great Completion, so my grandfather scolded me terribly."

"…"

Right. Of course.

As I stared at him in disbelief, Cheongpung muttered, "Still… it doesn't feel very good. Having someone copy my martial arts."

An ominous aura rose from him.

After regaining consciousness, Hyuk Mujin stared blankly at the training ground.

This is incredible.

The training ground had already been half reduced to rubble.

More than half of the bluestone carefully laid by stonemasons famous throughout Shanxi Province had been smashed apart, and the destruction was continuing at a rapid pace.

Clang! Ka-ka-ka-clang!

Despite the season, the center of the training ground was scorching hot. Spear and sword clashed amid bursts of flame.

The men wielding them moved at dazzling speed, exchanging blows so quickly that even Hyuk Mujin, a First Rate master, struggled to follow.

How can they be that fast?

Cheongpung wore white martial robes, while Jin Taekyung wore black. The stark contrast between them was obvious at a glance, yet it was astonishing that they were around the same age.

That Cheongpung fellow is a monster.

He had an average build and a gentle appearance. Spend half a day on the streets of Taiyuan, and one could probably find three or four young men his age who looked much like him.

But that ordinary-looking young man concealed an identity no one could easily have guessed.

The heir to everything Sword Saint Mae Jonghak possessed.

Whoosh! Swish!

Beneath the high sun, Jin Taekyung's spearhead flashed.

The forms were heavy and concise, but once power and speed were added, they transformed into an extremely fast spear technique that made Hyuk Mujin dizzy just watching it.

What if that spear were aimed at me?

Hyuk Mujin shook his head from side to side.

It was embarrassing, but he wasn't confident he could last even the time it took to drink a cup of tea. No, perhaps even that thought was merely a consolation meant to preserve his pride.

But Cheongpung was different.

Swish, swish-swish-swish!

The spearhead surged in from every direction, only to slice uselessly through empty air. Cheongpung's face remained calm as he effortlessly dodged every attack.

Then his hand blurred, and a streak of light split the air.

Whoosh! Boom!

"Hng!"

Jin Taekyung let out a groan amid the thunderous impact. He had barely blocked the sword, but sword strikes poured toward him like a torrential downpour.

Watching the scene, Hyuk Mujin opened his mouth without realizing it.

At that moment, a single thought filled his mind.

Graceful.

That was the only way to describe it.

Cheongpung's movements were delicate and fluid, like the brushstrokes of a master painter. They resembled flower petals drifting and fluttering down at the end of the season.

Hyuk Mujin watched in a daze before suddenly muttering, "Plum Blossom Sword Technique…"

He had never seen Huashan's martial arts before.

But he could be certain of one thing. The very essence of Huashan martial arts had seeped into every one of Cheongpung's movements.

He's a monster. A monster in every sense of the word.

But "monster" was not a word that applied only to Cheongpung.

Swish-swish-swish-swish!

Ka-ga-gang!

Another man was blocking every strike of the Plum Blossom Sword Technique unleashed by the Sword Saint's disciple.

The young man with a powerful build and striking, ruggedly handsome features ground his teeth.

"Fuck, Huashan really made its martial arts a goddamn nightmare!"

If Huashan had heard the thick profanity Jin Taekyung spat out, the entire sect would have turned upside down.

A rough aura poured from his body.

Its domineering force momentarily suppressed Cheongpung's fluid grace before flowing straight into a counterattack.

Whoooosh! Boom!

A ferocious strike.

Cheongpung went flying after blocking the spear amid the thunderous impact. Jin Taekyung had knocked aside Cheongpung's offensive with a single move, but he immediately frowned.

"Ow, that stings."

Slice.

Before his words had even ended, the black martial robes he wore split open in a long tear.

Several long wounds scored his exposed chest, blood welling freely from them.

"What martial art was that?"

"The Heavenly Eagle Claw."

"You really do have everything."

"Would you like me to teach you?"

"You're allowed to?"

"Oh, I just remembered. My grandfather told me not to teach it to outsiders."

"Again? I knew it."

"Would you like to join Huashan?"

"No!"

Jin Taekyung shouted and kicked off the ground, charging forward.

His movements were instinctive, like those of a wild beast, yet they barely retained the form of martial arts. Hyuk Mujin shuddered.

Why does that man get scarier the longer I watch him?

Everyone had their own distinctive aura.

Jin Taekyung's was tenacious and fierce. There was something about it that struck fear into anyone watching him.

It isn't about his martial arts.

Jin Taekyung was certainly a highly skilled master, but he was not yet the equal of Cheongpung, the Sword Saint's disciple and a true Peak master.

Yet Hyuk Mujin had watched him from close by for the past several months, and he could say this with certainty.

Even if the sky fell, that man would survive.

No matter what kind of hell Jin Taekyung was thrown into, Hyuk Mujin felt certain he would return alive.

Three Peak masters had tried to kill him so far, but in the end, they had been the ones to fall. In Murim, the one who survived was the strong one.

And Jin Taekyung had survived to the bitter end.

Besides…

Captain's rate of growth is beyond imagination.

It was something Hyuk Mujin knew because he had watched him from closer than anyone else.

From the moment Jin Taekyung defeated Jopil, One Question, One Kill, after a desperate battle to this very moment as he fought Cheongpung—

Jin Taekyung was growing stronger every day.

And that's still true right now.

Just a few days ago, he hadn't been able to last even a hundred moves against the supreme techniques of Huashan that Cheongpung unleashed.

But now?

Hyuk Mujin had personally watched them exchange well over three hundred moves. Even after being struck by the Heavenly Eagle Claw, a martial art taught only to disciples of Huashan's main sect, Jin Taekyung's sole reaction had been, "Ow, that stings."

He's a monster. A monster.

Everyone around them was around the same age, and they were all Peak or Supreme First Rate. Wasn't that taking things too far? It seemed as though nothing but monsters surrounded him.

Hyuk Mujin let out a deep sigh and recalled what Jin Taekyung had told him a few days earlier during their Wall Lizard Technique training.

"If you don't want to lose something precious, then risk your life and do it now. Working yourself to death while you're still breathing is better than dying, isn't it?"

Those words were true.

You had to work yourself to death to survive and become strong. Every second counted if you wanted to avoid being swept away by the waves of Murim.

After silently watching the two men spar for a while, Hyuk Mujin rose to his feet.

I can't finish this with just my little toe.

He had to become stronger. Strong enough to be recognized as Jin Taekyung's right arm—or perhaps his heart.

And…

Strong enough for everyone to remember the name Hyuk Mujin.

He gripped his sword case tightly.

Chapter 158

Seven days and nights.

Seven days and nights had passed since I began sparring with Cheongpung. Eyes closed, I thought,

According to the Quest Window, I have to defeat Cheongpung before New Year's Day…

Only three days remained. How many times had I fought Cheongpung by now?

All I knew was that we had dueled at least sixty times. Of course, I had lost every single one of them without exception.

And he hasn't even used Sword Energy.

Cheongpung wasn't fighting at full strength. For a Peak master, not using Sword Energy was an enormous handicap, but Cheongpung was still strong without it.

He had learned Huashan's supreme martial arts under the guidance of Sword Saint Mae Jonghak since childhood.

Even Jin Mukyung, considered one of the greatest young prodigies in the current orthodox Murim, had lost to Cheongpung.

Jin Mukyung was injured at the time, but… Cheongpung is definitely different.

I recalled Cheongpung's movements, which I had seen so many times that I was sick of them.

They were grace itself.

That was probably a characteristic of the martial arts he had learned, but it was only possible because his own strength supported them.

So he's simply a cut above me.

Of course, I hadn't shown him everything, right down to my underwear.

I still had One Annihilation, the Inventory System, and the Unnamed Sword, which could contend with Cheongpung's Sword Energy.

But this was a spar, not a life-and-death duel.

I have to beat him with martial arts.

As far as I was concerned, the System was my final card.

In a battle where the slightest margin could decide life or death, it could turn the tide. But if my attack was blocked even after I used the System, only death would await me.

It was literally my final card. There was nothing after that.

I can't rely on the System every time I fight.

The world was vast, and there were many masters.

To prepare for powerful enemies who could appear at any moment, sharpening my martial arts had to come first.

"Whew."

With a deep exhale, my forty-five years of internal energy, which had been flowing steadily through me, coiled once more within my dantian.

SYSTEM

You have successfully completed circulating your qi.
The realm of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique has risen slightly.
Your stamina and fatigue have recovered.

When I opened my eyes, the first thing I saw was Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin locked in a fierce battle.

Whack! Whack-whack-whack!

"Gaaagh!"

"..."

Correction. It wasn't a fierce battle. Mujin was just getting the crap beaten out of him.

Disoriented by the forms of the Crouching Tiger Fist raining down on him like a sudden shower, Hyuk Mujin gritted his teeth.

"Hah!"

The sword in his hand shot forward like a ray of light.

The forms weren't particularly unpredictable, nor did the sword technique reveal any extraordinary profundity, but his fundamentals were solid. He had probably swung that same sword thousands, perhaps tens of thousands, of times by now.

Swish! Swish-swish!

Head, shoulder, then chest. Cheongpung evaded all three attacks in an instant, only for Hyuk Mujin's sword to thrust toward his chest.

Whooosh!

A clean, sharp strike stripped of all unnecessary movement.

Unfortunately, he had picked the wrong opponent.

"Wow, you've improved a lot!"

The blade trembled violently between Cheongpung's index and middle fingers as Hyuk Mujin poured strength into it.

Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade.

It was a technique possible only when one's martial arts were overwhelmingly superior to one's opponent's.

Hyuk Mujin's face flushed red at the unexpected humiliation.

"Hngh!"

"Putting more strength into it won't—"

Cheongpung's eyes suddenly widened.

Hyuk Mujin had appeared to be putting more strength into the sword he had seized, but he abruptly released the hilt and lunged into Cheongpung's arms.

Look at that bastard.

A quiet laugh escaped me. I had a pretty good idea why Hyuk Mujin, who had fought so honestly until now, had suddenly tried something like that.

They say even a dog at a village school can recite poetry after three years.

It was a method I often used: abandon the weapon a martial artist valued as much as his own life, catch the enemy off guard, and seize the advantage.

A good attempt. His only mistake was trying it against someone far too skilled for such a trick to work.

Boom!

With a sound like a drum bursting, someone's body sailed through the air. Grinning, I looked down at Hyuk Mujin, who had landed right at my feet.

"Lose?"

After a fit of coughing and retching, Hyuk Mujin replied irritably,

"You watched the whole thing. Why ask?"

"What number was that?"

"That makes ninety."

"You'll hit a hundred soon. How about Hundred Battles, Hundred Losses as your nickname?"

"I'll pass."

"Still, that last move wasn't bad."

Hyuk Mujin's ears twitched at my praise.

"Really?"

"Yeah. But the difference in skill was way too great. Size up your opponent before trying that."

"I knew it. I was wondering why you were praising me for once."

"Do you think you could have landed even one hit with a move like that?"

"If Cheongpung hadn't used a palm technique, I could've hit him at least once."

As Hyuk Mujin grumbled with his lower lip sticking out, Cheongpung ran over with an innocent expression.

"Are you all right?"

"No, weren't you supposed to use only fist techniques?"

"I was going to start using palm techniques now. You've improved much faster than I expected."

"Ahem. Well, go ahead, then."

Look at that bastard. His grin was about to split his face.

Normally, I would have cut in to knock him down a peg, but I largely agreed with Cheongpung.

He really is improving quickly.

I wasn't the only one who had grown over the past week. Hyuk Mujin had as well.

Even though he had Cheongpung's help, he had completed his Wall Lizard Technique training despite having far inferior stats. He had also improved enough for Cheongpung to bring out his palm techniques first.

That's not all.

I activated Qi Sense to check Hyuk Mujin's Level.

SYSTEM

You used Qi Sense. At its current six-star realm, you can search for targets at Level 80 or below within 60 jang.[917]

Qi Sense has identified the target.

Lv. 50 Hyuk Mujin

Only ten days ago, Hyuk Mujin had been Level 48. But after training, he had gone up two Levels.

Level 50? Already?

By checking Levels with the System, I could roughly gauge an opponent's strength.

The problem was that most people's Levels either stagnated or rose so slowly that it was difficult to notice.

But this guy's Level keeps shooting up.

I suddenly remembered when I had first met Hyuk Mujin.

Back then, he had been only Level 20. He wasn't anywhere near me—I had already passed Level 60—but even so, his Level-up speed was no joke.

Maybe it's because he's been dragged around with me.

Now that I thought about it, he had gone through every kind of hardship while traveling with me. Had actual combat naturally trained him?

Under my gaze—as though I were studying some fascinating creature—Hyuk Mujin asked,

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Huh? Nothing. I was just thinking you really have improved a lot."

"Ahem. Ahem!"

"That was me being generous. From now on, you're my pinky."

"…You're awfully stingy."

"Never heard the phrase 'the painful pinky'?"

[917] A jang is ten Korean ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Sixty jang is about 182 m (597 ft); three jang is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

“So you’re saying I’m your painful pinky, Captain?”

“No. I’m just telling you the phrase exists. Remember it.”

“…”

“All right, our Great Hero Hyuk Mujin of Hundred Battles, Hundred Losses can step back now.”

“I told you I’m not using that nickname!”

Letting Hyuk Mujin’s shout go in one ear and out the other, I steadied my breathing and stepped forward.

“How about circulating your qi once?”

Cheongpung smiled brightly.

“I barely moved, so I didn’t even break a sweat. Why would I?”

Mujin was going to cry. He really was.

I smiled along with Cheongpung’s radiant expression.

“You’re going to sweat a little now.”

“Someone at your level is a fun opponent, Benefactor.”

That challenging tone was unusual for Cheongpung. But from everything I had seen, this was his true nature—the competitive spirit of Cheongpung the martial artist.

I clearly remembered how he hadn’t smiled even once while fighting Jin Mukyung with his sword.

“It won’t be fun much longer.”

“That’s all right. Winning is always fun. Hehe.”

“Sure you won’t regret saying that?”

“Yes! I’m already beating you without Sword Energy!”

“…”

Damn. That hit a nerve.

I calmed myself after that brutal statement of fact and tightened my grip on the spear.

“This time will be different.”

“My grandfather told me something. He said only weaklings say things like that. True masters show it through their actions.”

“Don’t worry. That’s what I intend to do now.”

“I’m looking forward to it.”

I looked at Cheongpung, who was still grinning from ear to ear, and murmured inwardly.

Open Status Window.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 64 Jin Taekyung
Job: First Rate martial artist
Fame: 2,400 (+250)
Titles: 5 (Title effects active)
- **Returnee** (All stats +10)
- **Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi** (All stats +15, Fame +200)
- **Scion of a Great Family** (All stats +5, Fame +50)
- **Gambler** (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one combat)
- **Intermediate Trainee** (Training speed +20%)

Strength: 205 (+30) **Stamina:** 207 (+30)
Agility: 200 (+30) **Intelligence:** 40 (+30)
Charm: 40 (+30) **Internal Energy:** 45 years
Toughness: 200 (+30)
Remaining Points: 100

- **Distribute your remaining points.**

My combat stats had finally broken through 200 thanks to training the Wall Lizard Technique and sparring. And I still had the points I had diligently saved in preparation for encountering an enemy.

At this moment, I didn't envy even the greatest under heaven.

"I was really saving these up… but I'm using them because of you."

"Huh?"

"Sword Energy, the Zaha Divine Technique—anything is fine. Give it everything you've got."

"Then it'll be too bland."

"You should taste it before deciding whether it's spicy or bland."

Before I had even finished speaking, an order had already been delivered to the System in my head.

Assign fifty points to Agility.

Whooosh.

It was a force only I could feel in this world.

The moment an unprecedented power, whose origin I could not identify, flowed through my entire body like a wave—

"Let's start with mild Neoguri."[918]

Whoooosh!

[918] Neoguri is an instant-noodle brand. Taekyung is using its mild flavor label to describe his attack.

My spear began moving faster than ever before.

Swish—boom!

Cheongpung twisted his neck. His hair, tied tightly behind his head, burst through the air.

But the spear didn't stop there.

Whoom—whooosh!

More than ten spear images charged in from every direction. Cheongpung stepped forward without hesitation.

Crack!

The few remaining bluestones shattered, and dirt erupted into the air.

Jin Taekyung looked at Cheongpung, who had retreated three jang[919] in an instant, and asked,

"Knew it. Dark Fragrance Drift?"

"I mixed in the Five-Element Plum Blossom Steps."

"Can you even do that?"

"It worked, didn't it?"

"So how does it taste?"

"Bland. Very bland."

"That's possible. For now."

After finishing his sentence, Jin Taekyung suddenly shuddered from head to toe and grinned.

"Next up: spicy Jin Ramen."[920]

The incomprehensible words had barely left his mouth when he charged.

The spearhead rose as if it would pierce the sun, then slashed downward with a terrifying sound as it tore through the air.

Whooooooosh!

At that moment, Cheongpung drew his sword. Vivid violet Sword Energy had already gathered along its blade.

No—the Zaha Divine Technique was flowing from his entire body, not just his sword.

Boom!

Force collided with force.

A thunderous roar rang out as though the sky itself were splitting apart.

---

[919] A jang is ten Korean ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Sixty jang is about 182 m (597 ft); three jang is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

[920] Jin Ramen is an instant-noodle brand with a spicy flavor variety.

The smile vanished from Cheongpung's lips. A considerable backlash traveled through his aching wrist.

How?

He was different. Far too different.

Even the phrase *looking at someone with new eyes* fell short.

Before Cheongpung could even rub his eyes, Jin Taekyung had grown stronger, then stronger again.

And his internal energy…

The Zaha Divine Technique was an Extreme Yang internal-energy cultivation technique. Yet the internal energy transmitted through Jin Taekyung's spear was no less powerful.

Cheongpung felt a faint tremor coming from the spearhead pressing down on his sword.

Vrrr. Vrrrr.

They said that those who reached the wall of the Peak realm could hear someone crying before breaking through it.

A martial artist's weapon, as precious as life itself, was the first to notice its owner's transformation.

Internal energy that had reached the realm. A physique fully prepared to become a Peak master.

When all of those conditions were met, this was the sound that rang out.

A Sword Cry?

But it wasn't a sword. It was a spear.

A Spear Cry.

As Cheongpung stared openmouthed, Jin Taekyung grinned.

"All right. Now for spicy Puramyeon."[921]

Krrrnnng.

With the force of a thousand geun,[922] the spear's cry rang out even louder.

[921] Puramyeon is an instant-noodle brand used as the last step in Taekyung's flavor joke.

[922] A Korean geun is a traditional unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is 600 kg (about 1,320 lb); here, the weight describes the spear's immense force.

Chapter 159

Fifty points to Agility. And fifty points to Strength.

That made a hundred points in total. I had poured them all in at once—a massive number of points that would normally take ten Level-ups to earn—but I didn't regret a single one.

Points really are the best. Always thrilling. Always new.

The toes kicking off the ground and the hand gripping the spear shaft cried out.

The me of now was far stronger than I had been only a few seconds ago.

And at last, I had taken the first step toward winning this duel.

I'll end this quickly.

Whooooooosh!

The instant the spearhead came crashing down with a terrifying sound, a violet haze rose from Cheongpung's entire body.

The Zaha Divine Technique.

It was proof that Cheongpung had finally begun fighting at full strength. But there was still one crucial thing left in this match.

Whoooosh!

As expected, a streak of Sword Energy shot up from Cheongpung's waist.

Sword Energy, the exclusive domain of Peak masters, possessed enough cutting power to slice through steel.

I hadn't yet crossed the wall into the Peak realm. I couldn't meet it head-on.

I had to either retreat a step or factor in the spear being destroyed and continue with my next attack.

But…

What is this feeling?

A strange sense of déjà vu. My heart pounded, and my vision grew sharp. In a world that seemed to have slowed down, the cool spear shaft in my grip trembled.

Vrrr. Vrrrr.

A cool head. A hot heart.

That was how I had fought for seven years…but this time was different. This was instinct. Nothing but instinct ruled over my entire being.

I can do it.

Like a man possessed, I put more strength into the descending spearhead.

Forty-five years of internal energy raced along my fingertips toward the spearhead. The trembling in my grip grew stronger, and Cheongpung's violet Sword Energy dazzled my eyes.

That was all.

Boom!

Two enormous forces collided.

A thunderous roar. A brutal blast of wind. Cheongpung's eyes flying wide.

And then…

It's fine.

The snow-white spearhead was still there.

It pressed down on Cheongpung's Sword Energy without so much as a hairline crack, trembling all the while.

Vrrrrrrr.

It sounded like hundreds of bees beating their wings.

How is this possible?

Was this also the effect of raising my Strength? Or was it simply a coincidence?

At that moment, the answer to my question rang out.

SYSTEM

You have finished preparing to step into a new realm.
Your weapon is resonating with your qi.
Quest *Beyond the Wall* has been generated.

Ah.

It wasn't the effect of raising my Strength. Nor was it a coincidence.

This was the natural order of things. After enduring countless hardships, I had finally come face-to-face with the wall. Now I had to cross it.

The wall of the Peak realm—a wall countless people had failed to overcome.

A Peak master.

True superhumans who wielded Sword Energy, or Aura.

A shiver ran through me at the thought alone. Memories from the past flashed before my eyes like a cheap monochrome film.

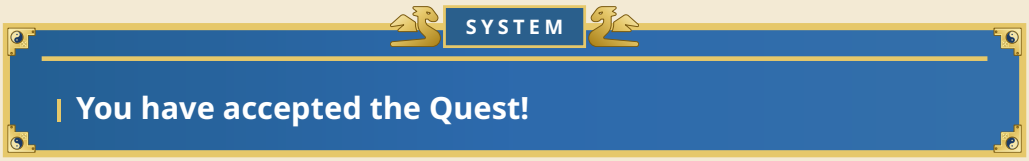
A mere F-rank Hunter, one of countless others, had made it this far. There had been countless crises, and someone had made a sacrifice.

SYSTEM

Quest: *Beyond the Wall*
Would you like to accept this Quest?
Y / N

I had crossed the boundary between life and death countless times. I had to cross a mere Peak wall with ease if I didn't want to be ashamed of the days I had lived through.

Obviously yes.



Ding.

As the cheerful System notification rang out, I pulled up the corners of my mouth.

My thoughts had been long, but only a short time had passed. I whispered to Cheongpung, who was looking up at me with bewildered eyes.

"Now, it's Puramyeon spicy flavor."[923]

I'll show you what Korean spice tastes like.

Krrrnnng.

My Strength had risen by twenty-five percent compared to roughly a minute ago.

It was the difference between heaven and earth. Cheongpung was visibly flustered by my sudden transformation.

"B-Benefactor. Where did this sudden strength come from?"

"It's Korean rice power. Especially gukbap."[924]

"Pardon?"

"I used to eat two bowls of pork-bone hangover soup every morning. And five bowls of rice."

"What does that even—gasp!"

Krrrnnng.

Cheongpung swallowed a breath as my force continued to build.

He had Sword Energy and the Zaha Divine Technique, but neither was having much effect. Filled to the brim with my qi and resonating with it, the spear had grown sturdy enough that even Sword Energy could no longer cut through it.

I have a real shot at winning.

But Cheongpung wasn't going down that easily.

"Hup!"

With a short shout, an incredible force knocked the spearhead upward.

---

[923] Puramyeon is an instant-noodle brand. Taekyung uses its spicy flavor as the next step in his escalating flavor joke.

[924] *Gukbap* is soup served with rice; *bone haejangguk* is a hearty pork-bone soup traditionally eaten as hangover food.

It had only been lifted a handspan, but the instant Cheongpung escaped the pressure, he didn't let the opportunity pass.

"I'm sorry. I took you far too lightly, Benefactor."

Before he had even finished speaking, an invisible force shot from his palm.

The Taeeul Miri Palm. A secret ultimate technique of Huashan, personally taught to him by the Sword Saint.

"Hngh!"

Bam-bam-bam!

Sharp pain shot through me as I staggered backward five steps in succession.

Thank goodness I had improved my bones and muscles as well as my Sinews and Meridians with every Level-up. Otherwise, I would have been in serious trouble.

"Damn, that hurt."

Cheongpung stared at me with the wide, startled eyes of a rabbit.

"A Seven-Star Taeeul Miri Palm…"[925]

"Don't say that. You'll make me crave cider."

"Pardon?"

There it was. Exactly the reaction I had expected.

The instant Cheongpung asked what I meant, my spear was already thrusting toward his chest.

A perfectly timed surprise attack. But there was no way it would end with just that.

As if answering my thoughts, Sword Energy slammed into the spearhead.

Clang!

I wasn't expecting it to work.

With no expectations came no disappointment. My emotions remained steady, and so did my forms.

Next, the waist.

Whoooosh!

Cheongpung twisted his waist as the spear moved.

The gust raised by the spearhead silently sliced through his shirt. A faint line of blood appeared across the exposed flesh.

A small gain was still a gain.

Next, the neck.

I turned with the motion and swung the spear shaft at Cheongpung's neck.

Boom!

[925]The Korean word for "seven-star" also appears in *Chilsung Cider*, a Korean lemon-lime soft drink, setting up Taekyung's next line.

That was not the sound that should have come from a collision between a human body and a steel spear.

But Cheongpung had martial arts—the Zaha Divine Technique, both one of the greatest internal-energy cultivation techniques under heaven and a protective qi art.

I clicked my tongue as I watched the violet energy around him grow denser.

Even so, how can there be absolutely no damage? This is outright cheating.

Talk about a plum-blossom silver spoon. How was I supposed to spar with this kind of unfair advantage?

But I didn't have time to complain. Cheongpung had closed the distance to right in front of me in barely half a step, and the Sword Energy he scattered filled my vision.

Whoooosh!

The tip of his sword bloomed with flowers.

The movement was so fluid it was beautiful. But if I let myself be mesmerized, I would soon find myself standing before a sign for Mount Beimang.[926]

The Plum Blossom Sword Technique I had watched until now was a frightening martial art composed of extremely intricate, complex forms.

When Cheongpung wielded it, it felt as though I were trapped in a rainstorm.

But…

I can see it.

I opened my eyes wide. My breathing slowed, and my vision sharpened. The sound of my heartbeat was like thunder, and the spear trembled in my hands.

Vrrrr. Vrrrrr.

The spear was ringing.

At this moment, the spear and I were practically one body.

The spear shaft no longer felt cool.

Shishishishik!

Sword and spear became a blur.

I continuously deflected and knocked away the Sword Energy pouring down like rain.

Ten times, twenty, maybe thirty…

Cheongpung was tenacious and sharp beyond anyone I had ever fought.

When I countered the Sword Energy digging toward my waist, the Taeeul Miri Palm flew at me. When I avoided the Taeeul Miri Palm, the Crouching Tiger Fist aimed for my chest.

Thud!

[926] Mount Beimang is traditionally associated with burial grounds. Taekyung means that losing focus could get him killed.

The shoulder that blocked the Crouching Tiger Fist throbbed.

A momentary pain. As my movements slowed for an instant, Cheongpung opened the fist he had curled shut.

Air burst from the tips of his five fingers.

Ah, damn it. Right, he had that too.

The moment I realized it, I bent my waist backward like a bow.

The Plum Blossom Five-Point Finger. He had shown it only once during his duel with Jin Mukyung.

Pip-pip-pit!

Five streams of finger force grazed the bridge of my nose and earlobe by a hair.

He really is strong.

I felt it again: Cheongpung was not an ordinary swordsman.

He was not only the heir of the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak. He had also mastered Huashan's secret techniques—in other words, he was a complete gift set of Huashan martial arts.

I wiped away the blood seeping from my wounds and spoke.

"You're coming on a little strong, aren't you?"

"That's what I'd like to say to you, Benefactor. Honestly, you surprised me."

"Why? Because someone who seemed like no big deal is fighting much better than expected?"

"Yes!"

"…"

"You're better than I thought. Seriously. And…"

"And?"

"It's fun."

As I watched the faint smile on Cheongpung's lips, I thought about it.

Setting his competitive pride aside, this guy simply loved martial arts themselves. He was proving to me how frightening a genius who truly enjoyed martial arts could be.

"Aren't you the same as me, Benefactor?"

"Young Hero Cheong, do you know what my dream is?"

"…"

"To retire in one piece and put up a building in my name. I'll collect rent and spend my old age in comfort as a landlord."

"A landlord?"

"Put simply, um… Yes. You can think of it as being one of those people up in the sky."

"Ah-ha."

Cheongpung nodded as though he understood.

“You want to become the Martial God.”

“No, that’s not what I meant. Where did the Martial God come from?”

“Is that not it?”

“No. It’s completely different.”

“But you do seem to like martial arts.”

“Me? Not to that extent.”

“You look happy for someone who doesn’t.”

Only then did I realize that the corners of my mouth had been raised the entire time.

Since when?

As I stood lost in thought, Cheongpung smiled brightly.

“If you’ve caught your breath, shall we start again?”

“…How long have you known?”

“It’s a method I’ve used on my grandfather many times.”

People really did think alike. I burst out laughing.

“You’re more perceptive than I expected.”

“My sword is faster.”

Tsssss.

The moment violet Sword Energy surged from Cheongpung’s blade, the spear in my hands trembled violently.

Clang!

The First Form of the Jin Family’s Spear Technique. The spear thrust straight ahead was blocked by the sword blade.

The Jin Family’s Spear Technique was an honest martial art. Simple and rough.

It was clearly a First Rate martial art, but when it came to subtle principles, it was far too simple.

Compared to Huashan’s secret techniques, it falls hopelessly short.

Martial arts ultimately came down to combinations of movements.

Thrusting, striking, cutting.

By circulating internal energy, adjusting the angle by the slightest degree, and linking one form into the next, one could create endless variations.

I had finally mastered them after arduous effort, but the Jin Family’s Spear Technique and the Jin Family’s Manoeuvre Technique lacked that sort of subtlety.

Whooooooosh! Clang!

In that respect, my opponent was a terrible match for me.

Cheongpung was a Peak master with eyes sharp enough to see through my martial arts at a glance.

As if he had decided to stop holding back, he began pressing the attack in earnest.

Whoosh! Bam-bam!

Sword techniques, fist techniques, palm techniques, water arts, even claw techniques.

He really was a genius of martial arts. He chained together roughly ten different martial arts, yet every movement fit perfectly into the next, like interlocking gears.

His eyes shone like morning stars, and his breathing was slow and steady.

So this is what it means to be the Sword Saint's Disciple.

An excellent Master and excellent martial arts.

And talent on top of that.

The world was always unfair. And over the past seven years, I had learned how to adapt to that unfair world.

Persist, move slowly, and never give up.

That was my way.

I had never wanted to be a tortoise that caught up with a rabbit far ahead.

Crossing the finish line was enough.

Surviving and retiring. That was the greatest dream a lowest-rank Hunter could have.

I had to claw my way to survival.

I learned everything in the Gates. Goblins holding rusty knives and firing poison needles were my sparring partners.

Unlike duels in the Murim, I had to stake my life on every fight. But that was why I learned faster.

And then…

I came to the Murim.

Clang-clang-clang! Slash!

My side burned. I could feel blood flowing, but I didn't make the stupid mistake of checking the wound.

The human body was weaker than you might think, and stronger in its own way. Even if some blood was flowing, the bleeding would soon stop once it clotted.

"Ugh!"

Funny enough, Cheongpung's weak stomach gave me an opening.

I charged at the faltering Cheongpung.

Second Form of the Jin Family's Spear Technique.

Whooooooosh!

It had been about a week after I fell into the Murim, I think.

I found two martial arts manuals in a dust-covered archive: the Jin Family's Spear Technique and the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique.

If you asked why I learned them, the answer was simple.

To survive.

To me, the Murim was another Gate.

I had to learn if I wanted to survive.

That was how I entered the world of martial arts. Before I knew it, several months had passed.

And then everything changed completely.

Shishishishik! Bam!

Hngh.

The Plum Blossom Five-Point Finger.

The instant I avoided the five streams of finger force, the Taeeul Miri Palm struck me.

I had poured in a full hundred points, but I still hadn't caught up to Cheongpung.

However, to fight someone who already knew the Jin Family's Spear Technique inside and out, I had no choice but to keep charging forward like a rhino.

Third Form of the Jin Family's Spear Technique. Fourth Form.

The Jin Family's Spear Technique grew more powerful the farther it advanced. Its footwork was designed to match.

The essence of both arts was to pressure an opponent with simple forms tailored for actual combat.

If I can't do it with my teeth, I'll do it with my gums.

My understanding of martial arts might be lacking, but my stats were not inferior.

As I pressed forward, Cheongpung retreated.

Riding the momentum, I thrust and slashed with all my strength. Even as I panted until my mouth tasted sweet, I suddenly remembered the conversation I had just had with Cheongpung.

But you like martial arts, don't you?

Me? Not to that extent.

Then why have you been smiling this whole time?

That was obviously because…

It's fun.

Whoooooosh! Boom!

Sword and spear collided.

The bluestone laid neatly across the training ground shattered into powder and scattered through the air.

As the thick cloud of dust cleared, Cheongpung came into view.

His smile was clear and bright, completely at odds with the situation we were in.

“Martial arts are fun, right?”

After thinking for a moment, I nodded without a word.

“Why did you say they weren’t earlier?”

“Let’s just call it a difference in how we’ve lived.”

For seven years, I had lived as though I were being chased by something invisible.

Guilt, perhaps. Or a sense of responsibility.

Or maybe it was simply self-satisfaction, a way to rationalize all of it.

As he watched me hesitate, Cheongpung spoke.

“My grandfather once told me something. He said, ‘Martial arts? They’re nothing special!‘”

“Hmm? The Sword Saint?”

“It’s true.”

Cheongpung continued with an aggrieved expression.

“He said it wasn’t martial arts, but empty space[927]. Since it’s empty to begin with, you just accept it as it is and fill it in.”

“Accept it as it is and fill it in.”

“I’m serious. You can ask my grandfather later…”

Cheongpung’s voice gradually faded, then cut off completely.

I closed my eyes.

In the pitch-black darkness, forgetting the passage of time and the place I was in, I muttered a single sentence as though possessed.

Accept it as it is and fill it in…

Why did those words keep catching at my heart?

The more I repeated them, the harder my heart pounded and the more my entire body itched.

It felt as though the boulder weighing down my chest were shifting.

It isn’t martial arts. It’s empty space. Accept it as it is and fill it in…

I didn’t know whether several seconds or several hours passed.

In the darkness, even the flow of time seemed to have stopped.

In that suffocating darkness, where it would not have been strange for a day, two days, three days, or even a year to pass, I opened my eyes.

“Benefactor, how do you feel?”

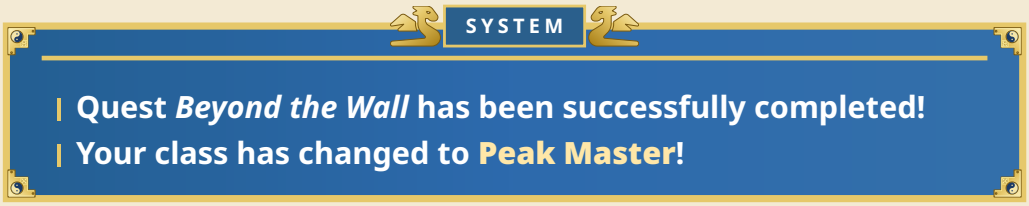
Instead of answering Cheongpung’s question, I looked around.

Hyuk Mujin was dozing in the corner, while the ink-dark sky was filled with a cluster of stars that looked ready to pour down at any moment.

Was this really the world I knew?

[927] Mae’s line is wordplay on two Korean terms pronounced *mugong*: “martial arts” and “empty space.”

“Was my grandfather right?”
His second question.
I answered in a hoarse voice.
“No. Not at all.”
Martial arts were fucking hard.
Still…
Ding.



Now I knew one thing.

Chapter 160

"Was Grandfather right?"

"No. Not at all."

There was a simple reason I was flatly denying the words of Mae Jonghak, the great martial artist known as the Sword Saint.

Look at the Sword Saint trying to con me.

Nothing special, my ass.

They said the view changed depending on where you stood. Beyond the wall of the Peak realm I had barely managed to cross, a rugged mountain range awaited me.

I still have a long way to go.

They said there was no end to learning. Martial arts were no different.

I was nothing more than a beginner who had barely gained enlightenment from a casual remark tossed out by the max-level Sword Saint.

Still…

"Thank you."

When I bowed with those heartfelt words, Cheongpung panicked.

"Benefactor, why are you suddenly doing this?"

"Because I'm grateful. That's all."

I knew there were countless martial artists, as numerous as grains of sand on a white-sand beach. I also knew that only a tiny fraction of them reached the Peak realm.

I also knew that even with advanced First Rate martial arts and internal energy, anyone without the enlightenment to match would spend their entire life stuck in place.

If not for Cheongpung, I would have wandered for a long time.

But I had been lucky. Cheongpung had devoted nearly ten days to helping me train, and he had even passed on the Sword Saint's teachings.

That was far too generous a return for a few candied hawthorn skewers.[928]

"Please don't do this. I barely did anything."

"Barely? I may be shameless, but I'm not an ungrateful bastard."

"Huh? Really?"

"…"

Just what did this guy think of me?

As my eyes narrowed, Cheongpung hurriedly waved his hands.

"No, that's not what you're thinking."

"What am I thinking?"

[928] Candied hawthorn skewers are traditional fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

“I mean, it’s just…”

Cheongpung looked around with a lost gaze, then spotted Hyuk Mujin snoring in the corner of the training ground and shouted.

“Young Hero Hyuk! Wake up! This isn’t the time to be sleeping.”

“…”

This was genuinely pathetic.

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes suddenly flew open at Cheongpung’s shout. When he saw me, he spoke as though nothing had happened.

“As expected. I believed in you.”

“…”

This bastard was taking it even further.

“I, Hyuk Mujin, stood guard with the single noble purpose of protecting my Captain.”

“…”

“Enlightenment is hard-won and easily broken. So I stood right here! Eyes wide open! Making sure not even a single rat could get through!”

Forget the rat. You sure seem like a fucking bastard…

I stared at him, saliva stains covering the area around his mouth, and quietly spoke.

“Mujin.”

“Yes, sir!”

“I’ve become a Peak Master, you know?”

“Congratulations!”

“Yeah. And now my body is overflowing with strength. My fists are itching, too.”

“…”

“Guard duty? Rats? If your snoring had been even a little louder, I might have suffered qi deviation, you bastard.”

“…You heard me?”

“Did you think I wouldn’t?”

He had been snoring so loudly that even my mother in Ilsan probably heard him.

As he scratched the back of his head and grinned sheepishly, I spread my fingers wide.

“This is your last chance. I’m counting to ten, so get out of my sight. One, two, three…”

Dadadadada!

Cheongpung watched Hyuk Mujin flee at tremendous speed and exclaimed in admiration.

“Wow, training really does work! He’s incredibly fast!”

So that was how he interpreted it.

I said to Cheongpung, who was clapping like a seal and looking proud of himself.

“Then let’s start again.”

“Huh?”

“The duel. It isn’t over yet.”

“I’m fine with that, but… Aren’t you tired?”

“Not at all.”

It was a lie. My body, having entered a new realm, was overflowing with vitality, but my mind was utterly exhausted. It felt like the strength had gone out of me after an all-out sprint.

But I wanted to continue sparring with Cheongpung even more.

I want to test it.

Gaining enlightenment was worlds apart from raising my stats with points.

Right now, I felt as though I could unleash martial arts that were entirely new—not merely faster or stronger.

“I’m perfectly fine.”

I said it again, but Cheongpung shook his head.

“My grandfather said rest is also training.”

“Not even once?”

“No. Benefactor, you need to rest now. And…”

“And?”

Cheongpung giggled as he continued.

“I’m going to win anyway. So what’s the point?”

“…!”

“You know that now too, don’t you?”

“That… is true.”

I didn’t want to admit it, but it was a fact.

You could only see as much as you knew. After reaching the Peak realm, I realized all over again just how much of a monster Cheongpung was.

I also realized that, as I was now, I could never defeat him if he fought at full strength.

Unless he went easy on me.

But that was not what I wanted. Winning a duel against an opponent who was not giving his all would only leave a bitter taste.

“Don’t be impatient. For the time being, you’ll have your hands full just absorbing the enlightenment you gained today.”

“Then…”

“Let’s postpone our duel until next time. It’s a shame. I was having fun too.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest *Sword Saint Training: A Secondhand Experience—2* has been canceled.
Since the Quest proposer made the decision themselves, you will not receive any penalty.

"Get plenty of rest today!"

I watched Cheongpung's back recede for a long time before returning to the pavilion.

The System notifications reminded me of the things I had been putting off.

Check messages.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Endless System notifications rang out as all the messages I had yet to check unfolded before my eyes.

I stared at the translucent System window with my mouth hanging open.

How many of these are there?

It looked like I would have to wait quite a while before I could rest.

Hot water sloshed inside the large wooden bathtub.

I had gone several days without washing properly and desperately needed a bath. As soon as I sank into the steaming tub, a moan escaped me.

"Ahhh. This feels great."

Now I finally felt alive again. After closing my eyes and savoring the sensation for a while, I opened the System window.

"Check messages."

Ding. Ding. Ding.

System messages poured out like water bursting through a broken dam. I read them one by one.

SYSTEM

You have successfully completed Quest *Beyond the Wall*!
Your class has changed to Peak Master!
You have acquired a massive amount of EXP!
Level up!
Level up!
Level up!
Level up!
Level up!

Oh. I gained five Levels at once?

Someone might think that was stingy, but not me.

The Murim was another reality, but I was practically a game character here.

Back when I was a beginner, killing a single bandit could raise my Level. Things were different now. The amount of EXP required kept increasing, and my leveling speed had been slowing down accordingly.

This is more than enough.

But the rewards did not end there.

SYSTEM

The realm of *Jin Family's Cultivation Technique* has risen to the ninth stage.
You can now acquire more internal energy with greater stability.
The realm of *Qi Sense* has risen to the seventh stage.
You can detect targets at Level 90 or below within 70 jang.[929]
You have acquired EXP due to the dramatic advancement of your martial arts.
Level up!
Level up!

I was already satisfied that the realms of Jin Family's Cultivation Technique and Qi Sense, which had stagnated for so long, had risen. Gaining two more Levels on top of that was a double blessing.

Just from the messages I had seen so far, I had already leveled up seven times.

Now that's a proper reward.

I smiled contentedly and continued reading the other messages.

[929] A *jang* is ten *ja*, a traditional length unit. Seventy jang is about 212 m (696 ft).

SYSTEM

A Peak Master is a powerhouse capable of leading an entire school. You can create your own martial art and establish a new sect.

You have gained insight into the manipulation of internal energy that you had not known before. Through training, you can use the new Skill *Sound Transmission*.

Creating a sect and inventing martial arts.

The System was certainly giving me the full Peak Master treatment. It was worlds apart from how I had been treated as a First Rate martial artist.

Well, I am a Peak Master now.

Shanxi was crawling with thousands of martial artists. Even so, there were fewer than twenty Peak masters.

I didn't know how things were in the Central Plains, but at least in Shanxi Province, that was what it meant to be a Peak master.

But none of that is very useful to me.

I didn't know anything about inventing martial arts yet, and I had no intention of founding a new sect. Why would I leave the dependable Jin Family of Taiyuan?

More importantly…

Sound Transmission is good. Very good.

Sound Transmission. A technique for secretly transmitting sound through internal energy.

I couldn't think of any immediate use for the first two, but Sound Transmission had considerable practical value.

It would require training, but that was no problem.

Only three left now?

The countless message windows had all disappeared, leaving exactly three.

With equal parts relief and regret, I checked the remaining messages.

Ding.

SYSTEM

***Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron* has been added to your Inventory.**

A martial artist and their weapon are one body. Finding a weapon capable of drawing out all of one's strength is also a martial artist's duty.

Quest *Find the Craftsman* has been created.

"…Huh?"

Northern Gaoyuan.

This land had once been home to the nomadic empire founded by a great ruler. But it had changed with the passage of time.

The vast pastures covered in green grass were gradually disappearing, and wooden buildings from the Central Plains were beginning to replace the gers, the nomads' homes.[930]

The customs of the nomads still remained, but the clothing and culture of the Central Plains were slowly infiltrating the plateau.

The man draped in sheepskin did not like it.

"Han Chinese bastards swarming the sacred grasslands."

"Temur, bear with it. It's not as if this started today or yesterday."

"Chinggen. We are descendants of the khans. We must not forget that."

"I haven't forgotten. I'm simply telling you not to forget what kind of gathering this is."

"Damn it. An inn instead of a perfectly good ger.[931]"

Temur and Chinggen, two chieftains who each commanded a hundred tribespeople, entered the inn.

Built by Han Chinese who called themselves mounted bandits, it was the only establishment of its kind in Northern Gaoyuan—and it was enormous to match.

The moment the two men stepped inside, they saw mounted bandits packed all the way to the upper floor, along with two men seated at the center of the crowd.

"Ha-ha-ha! The chieftains of the Great Steppe have arrived! Come, sit. I've warmed some mare's-milk wine for you."[932]

Unlike the middle-aged man who welcomed them with both arms spread wide, the other man did not so much as nod. He merely gestured.

"Sit."

"…!"

"…!"

Veins bulged on Temur and Chinggen's foreheads.

Who were they? They were descendants of the Great Khan who had once crossed the steppe and ruled the Central Plains.

It had happened centuries ago, but their pride had never died.

"You Han Chinese bastard, lower than a dog!"

---

[930] A *ger* is a traditional round felt dwelling used by nomadic peoples of the Central Asian steppe.
[931] A *ger* is a traditional round felt dwelling used by nomadic peoples of the Central Asian steppe.
[932] Mare's-milk wine is a traditional alcoholic drink made by fermenting mare's milk.

Temur was hot-tempered and reckless by nature. Before Chinggen could stop him, his hand seized his curved saber.

"I'll offer your head to the god Tengger—"[933]

And that was when it happened.

"I said sit."

The voice was cold, and the eyes were like an abyss. Even Temur, who led a tribe across the harsh steppe, found himself unable to draw his saber.

Seizing the moment, Chinggen hurriedly grabbed Temur by the shoulder and whispered so quietly that he could barely be heard.

"Temur, don't act rashly. You know who he is, don't you?"

Temur swallowed.

Four people had gathered here today. They had never met before, but each was a powerhouse who held up one of the major forces of Northern Gaoyuan.

But if there was a master capable of intimidating him this badly…

There was only one person.

The Human Butcher.

No one knew his surname. No one knew his name.

No one knew where he came from or what he had done.

He was Han Chinese, and he had ridden across the steppe with only fifty subordinates. He had earned the nickname Human Butcher because he killed people as though slaughtering livestock.

In other words, he was a butcher of men.

"You're a slow one, friend."

[933]Tengger is a sky deity in traditional steppe belief.

Chapter 161

“You’re a slow one, friend.”

The Human Butcher’s words sent a chill through Temur. He could feel the killing intent lurking like a dagger beneath the man’s calm voice.

They call him the Human Butcher, but what the hell is with that killing intent…?

But he could not back down here.

The tribespeople he had brought for this gathering, along with the Han Chinese mounted bandits, were watching his every move.

Damn it.

His honor as a chieftain clashed with his last shred of reason.

Should he draw his saber or not? As Temur wavered, a burst of laughter came to his rescue.

“Ha-ha-ha! As expected of the heroes of the world. A timid little man like me is too frightened to get involved.”

Temur looked toward the source of the laughter.

“Who are you?”

“Me?”

The middle-aged man, whose hair was half gray, smiled warmly.

If not for the eyepatch covering one eye, he would have looked as gentle as a kindhearted merchant.

“I have two names. I abandoned one when I left my homeland, while the other was given to me by friends I met on the steppe. Which one are you curious about?”

Temur did not need to answer. The Human Butcher revealed the man’s identity for him.

“Black Sand. Enough of your pointless drivel.”

“Oh, come now. What kind of person gives someone away like that? I was just getting to the fun part.”

“It wasn’t fun at all.”

“That’s why people call you a butcher. Tsk, tsk.”

As Temur and Chinggen realized who the middle-aged man was, their eyes widened.

“Black Sand? The Black Sand Band?”

“You’re that man?”

The eyepatched middle-aged man, Black Sand, nodded readily.

“That’s right. I’m Black Sand.”

“…”

“…”

The Black Sand Band. Composed entirely of Han Chinese, they ranked among the strongest powers on the harsh steppe.

There were only a hundred of them, but every single one was said to be a master of mounted combat and a martial artist of exceptional skill.

To think the leader of the Black Sand Band was such a frivolous man.

Chinggen was astounded.

So that's why that vicious Human Butcher didn't react when he was called a butcher.

Only Black Sand could get away with such a thing. Anyone else would already have had his tongue torn out and his head cut off by the Human Butcher.

But…

"Why are you here?"

As his surprise faded, Temur also gave Black Sand a suspicious look.

"I'd like to ask you the same thing."

Black Sand smiled faintly at their open wariness.

"Didn't you receive a letter?"

Temur and Chinggen both flinched.

"A letter?"

"How did you know about that?"

"Because I'm the one who sent it."

"That's impossible. The letter clearly bore the seal of the Heavenly Wind Band Leader."

Unlike the bewildered Temur, Chinggen seemed to have grasped part of the situation. He regarded Black Sand with a grave gaze.

"What is your relationship with the Heavenly Wind Band Leader? Where is he now?"

"So you're Chinggen. I've heard you're calm and sharp for a young chieftain."

"That isn't the answer I want."

"What a frightening look. How am I supposed to speak with you glaring at me like that? Still, now that you're here, there's no point keeping it secret. I'll tell you."

After that bit of banter, Black Sand continued.

"The Heavenly Wind Band Leader has been roaming around near Datong under my orders, drawing attention."

Under his orders.

The implication was obvious.

We've been completely fooled all this time.

The Heavenly Wind Band Leader was clearly Black Sand's subordinate. That meant the Heavenly Wind Band, which numbered a full five hundred, was merely an organization under the Black Sand Band.

Temur and Chinggen exchanged silent glances.

The Black Sand Band is already strong enough. And if you add the Heavenly Wind Band…?

It would be more than enough to change the balance of power on the steppe.

A deep smile spread across Black Sand's lips as he watched them.

"You two seem to have a lot on your minds."

"To be honest, this has caught us off guard."

"What exactly are you plotting?"

"Plotting? I'm simply proposing a deal that benefits us all. You would know that if you read the letter."

Temur and Chinggen recalled the letter they had received fifteen days earlier.

The letter, tied to an arrow and shot to them, contained one short line.

If you want to become a khan, come.

Khan! The ruler of the steppe, a great king commanding countless warriors.

The mere thought was enough to make their blood boil—especially for two young, powerful chieftains who dreamed of restoring their clans to glory.

"The steppe is fractured into pieces these days. It's hard to believe when you think of the glorious great empire founded by your ancestors."

Black Sand swirled his mare's-milk wine as he continued.

"If you help me, I'll help you in return. Weapons, horses, wealth. If necessary, I'll even send you some of my subordinates. Unite the fragmented steppe. Bring your enemies to their knees and force them to swear absolute obedience. I guarantee that you can become the khan of the Great Steppe within ten years."

"Easy for you to say."

Unlike the sarcastic Temur, Chinggen remained calm.

"Why us?"

"Because you're young, capable, and ambitious. Your legitimacy as descendants of the khans played a part as well. In any case, my proposal is simple."

Black Sand pushed a hard lump of dried horse dung into the dying fire. Flames leaped up, flickering in his eyes.

"Would you care to seize a city with me?"

"A city? You mean Shanxi?"

"Where else?"

Only then did the two chieftains roughly grasp his intentions. He intended to force his way into the power vacuum left by the collapse of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

The problem was that, for all his grand talk of khans and support, his proposal held little appeal for them.

“None of you look very pleased.”

Chinggen answered with a dissatisfied look.

“If you’re thinking of raiding the north now that it has no master, wouldn’t that be difficult?”

“Why?”

“Because the Jin Family of Taiyuan is moving quickly. I’ve heard they’re establishing branches throughout the north, and the government is getting involved as well.”

Even they had a line they could not cross.

Attacking merchant caravans made them mounted bandits. Invading a city and plundering civilians would make them rebels.

If an army of tens of thousands were dispatched to suppress the rebellion, they would have no way to oppose it.

“I don’t want to be driven out of my homeland. Nor do I want to die a dog’s death like Pung Yang.”

Temur nodded at Chinggen’s words. Hot-tempered though he was, he had to acknowledge reality.

“That bastard Pung Yang never even touched the government. The Jin Family of Taiyuan’s young brats killed him.”

“Pung Yang had nearly four hundred men. Fewer than one in ten returned alive.”

The Human Butcher, who had been listening in silence, suddenly spoke.

“Pung Yang was a man who fled from the steppe. The people under him were nothing more than a bunch of ragtag strays he hastily gathered.”

“You’ve met Pung Yang?”

“Once or twice. He was nothing special. I can say this with certainty: no one here is weaker than he was. Ah, that includes that idiot, of course.”

“You bastard!”

“Lower your voice before I carve out your Adam’s apple.”

“The Han Chinese bastard is all talk. You think you can do it?”

“Of course. Right now, if you want.”

Schriing.

Just as the blades at both men’s waists slid from their sheaths—

“Oh, honestly. That’s enough.”

No one there could ignore Black Sand, whether because of his age or the power he commanded.

After the two men exchanged a tense battle of wills and sheathed their weapons at the same time, Black Sand laughed as though he found it amusing and spoke to Chinggen.

"You don't need to worry about the government. This will end as a matter between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and us."

"What do you mean?"

"If we finish the job like a bolt of lightning, before anyone has time to react, what can they do?"

"Do you think that's possible? Shanxi Province is practically in the Jin Family of Taiyuan's hands already. Even if we break through Datong, the family's main force and countless small and medium-sized sects will be waiting for us by then."

"What if we strike before they gather? And target only their heads?"

"…What?"

"In three days, on the coming New Year's Day, the heads of every sect in Shanxi Province will gather at the Jin Family of Taiyuan. We'll enter through Hequ instead of Datong, then charge straight toward Taiyuan."

"…!"

"If we keep our weapons to a minimum and secure hardy steppe horses with excellent endurance, we can easily cover five hundred li in a day.[934] We can strike the enemy in as little as two days, or three at the most."

Crossing half of Shanxi Province to strike directly at the enemy's head.

The plan was so bold—and so reckless—that Chinggen's voice trembled.

"W-Wait. What if they realize what we're doing in advance and prepare?"

"Prepare? What exactly do you mean?"

"As I said, branches of the Jin Family of Taiyuan are being established throughout the north. If we advance while fighting our way through each one, we'll lose our mobility. If we ignore them and pass by, they'll hear about us before we even arrive."

"Don't worry about that. We only need to smash one—the Hequ branch."

"Then what about the others?"

"By then, they'll be locked in a bloody battle at Datong."

"Datong… Ah. You can't mean—"

"The Heavenly Wind Band Leader will do his part. I told him to run wild without restraint on that day."

Everyone knew the Heavenly Wind Band as a major power of the northern plateau.

In both numbers and individual skill, they were at least the equal of the Red Wind Band, if not superior.

[934] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi); five hundred *li* is 250 km (about 155 mi).

“In half a day, the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s branches throughout the north will be empty. With a fire burning in front of them, do you think they’ll have time to look behind them?”

Black Sand’s words were exactly right. The branches would scrape together every martial artist they had and send them to Datong to stop the Heavenly Wind Band. Taking advantage of that opening, the real main force would cross Hequ and advance south.

Trampling everything in their way beneath their horses’ hooves…

“Also, the Jin Family of Taiyuan is currently devoting all its strength to stabilizing the north. From what I’ve learned, there might not even be a hundred martial artists in the main family.”

Black Sand’s voice continued.

“This is a gathering attended by every sect in Shanxi Province. No matter how large the Jin Family of Taiyuan is, it can’t feed and house all of them. Even if you add every martial artist remaining at the main family, there may be only two hundred.”

Chinggen’s throat went dry. The forces under the people gathered here alone totaled three hundred without difficulty.

No, if they scraped together every last man, they could field twice that number.

We won’t be outmatched even in a battle between masters.

Black Sand. The Human Butcher. Temur and Chinggen.

All four gathered here were exceptional Peak masters.

According to the Human Butcher, who had personally met the late Pung Yang, not one of them was weaker than Pung Yang in martial arts.

But the Heaven Shaking Sword and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi from the Jin Family of Taiyuan only barely defeated Pung Yang after joining forces.

That had already been confirmed as fact.

Pung Yang had even defeated the Tiger of Mount Heng, a veteran of the martial world. As a result, rumors had spread that the mounted bandits of the northern plateau were stronger than most First Rate martial artists.

This might actually…

Black Sand watched Chinggen sink into thought, amusement glinting in his eyes.

“What do you say?”

Temur, who had been listening with hard swallows, shouted.

“Damn it! How can you tell me about such a fantastic plan and then ask what I think? I’m in, no matter what!”

“I’ll accept as well.”

Chinggen finally finished thinking and agreed. The Human Butcher cut in with a vicious smile.

“I don’t need anything else. Just leave Ghost Sword Wipeng to me.”

“Of course. You have my word.”

Black Sand looked around at the three men, a broad smile covering his face.

Now that they had accepted his proposal, he had effectively become the presiding chair.

“Everything we gain from this will be divided into four equal shares. If anyone breaks that agreement, I’ll chase him to the ends of the world and cut off his head. Any objections?”

“None.”

“Me neither.”

“Keep the promise written in the letter.”

“Of course.”

Black Sand answered readily, filled an empty bowl with mare’s-milk wine, and passed it around.

“Now that we’ve sealed our resolve, let’s get thoroughly drunk today!”

“Waaaaah!”

“Let’s drink! Bring more wine!”

Cheerful shouts erupted from every corner of the inn.

They were raising their bowls amid an atmosphere as heated as the mare’s-milk wine itself when—

Creeeeak.

Amid the uproar, the inn’s door opened, and someone stepped inside.

Chapter 162

There are moments when a place bursting with noise suddenly falls silent.

This was one of them.

Creeeeak.

The inn went quiet as its old door swung open.

The four leaders had been raising a toast to their plan to turn Shanxi Province upside down. Now, their gazes—and those of the more than two hundred mounted bandits and nomads around them—all turned toward the entrance.

Step. Step. Step.

What the…?

Black Sand's eyes narrowed as the uninvited guest slowly approached.

What's with this old man?

The intruder was an old man. Quite literally, an extremely old man.

Black Sand had never seen anyone as ancient as the figure shuffling toward them.

He's practically a corpse.

He tottered as though he might collapse at any moment. His wrinkled skin looked frozen stiff, and each breath that escaped his lips was faint and shallow.

Temur, Chinggen, and the Human Butcher watched him for a moment before exchanging a few words.

"That's the oldest person I've ever seen. He's even older than our tribe's shaman."

"But what's an old man doing here? And why does he look like that?"

"He must have run into some mounted bandits."

The old man did indeed look utterly wretched. His clothes hung in tatters, as though he had suffered some terrible misfortune, exposing a body that was little more than skin and bones.

"What an unlucky old man. He barely survives, only to end up in a mounted-bandit den."

The Human Butcher clicked his tongue.

"I don't even feel like killing someone that old. Get rid of him."

"Yes, sir."

His subordinate was about to step forward when—

"Wait."

Black Sand raised a hand to stop him. His brow furrowed as he stared at the old man.

Something's strange.

Mounted bandits had built this inn. Its owner, cook, and servers were all either mounted bandits or former ones.

As the only neutral ground in Northern Gaoyuan, it sometimes hosted gatherings and reconciliations like the one taking place today.

But he came crawling into a place like this on his own? An old man like that?

Anyone who set foot in Northern Gaoyuan knew about this inn.

They also knew that any ordinary civilian who entered it was as good as dead.

"What is it?"

"Shh. Wait a moment. Something about this doesn't feel right."

Black Sand's reaction made the others notice the oddity as well.

"Come to think of it, how did he get here?"

"He looks like an outsider…"

"He couldn't have come from outside. There's no way an old man like that could have made it here in one piece."

Hundreds of mounted-bandit groups and nomadic tribes were scattered throughout Northern Gaoyuan. No one without extraordinary nerve would even consider crossing the plateau alone.

The four men, including Black Sand, fell into thought.

Could he be…?

It would be possible if he were a martial artist.

A martial artist? That old man?

He bothers me. I should kill him.

To the Human Butcher, murder was hardly different from breathing. He reached for his scabbard without hesitation, but Black Sand shot him a glare.

A thread of Sound Transmission pierced the Human Butcher's ear.

—I told you to wait. It won't be too late to act after we watch him a little longer. Haven't you ever heard that in the Murim, you should beware of women, children, and old men?

—You worry too much. Over that sickly old man?

—Don't act rashly. You never know what might happen in the Murim.

The old man looked as though a single poke would kill him.

Still, the Human Butcher could not simply ignore Black Sand's warning.

With an irritated sigh, he took his hand off his scabbard.

—Good choice.

By then, the mysterious old man had tottered all the way up to the four men.

A strange tension hung in the air. The old man looked around through hazy eyes, then opened his mouth.

"W-Water…"

At the sound of his parched voice begging for water, everyone shook their heads as if to say, *Of course.*

Everyone except Black Sand. Careful and calculating by nature, he refused to lower his guard until the very end.

"The elder seems thirsty. Bring him some cool water."

"Yes, sir."

A mounted bandit handed the old man a cup, and he gulped down the water as though his life depended on it. He drank so frantically that it seemed he might collapse.

Only after downing five or six cups in succession did he finally raise his head.

"Whew."

"Feeling better now?"

A broad smile spread across the old man's wrinkled face.

"Yes!"

"…"

"Thank you, mister!"

Mister?

Startled, Black Sand shot to his feet and seized the old man's wrist.

There was no resistance. No strength whatsoever. His gaunt bones felt as though they might snap under the slightest pressure.

"Elder?"

"Yes? Why?"

The old man smiled and spoke like a child. Black Sand stared at him, and his expression twisted.

"Damn it. He's senile."

All the tension drained out of him. He had definitely sensed something strange, but apparently it had all been in his head.

With such an important undertaking ahead of him, his nerves were bound to be on edge.

As Black Sand shook his head, the Human Butcher laughed at him.

"You said anything could happen in the Murim, and you were right. An old man suffering from the infirmities of old age! Ha-ha-ha!"

"Shut your mouth."

Black Sand answered curtly and started to release the old man's wrist.

That was when—

"Where the hell is this?"

His voice was sharp and clear, completely different from before. His eyes had suddenly regained their focus. He looked around, then heaved a deep sigh.

"Damn it. Once you get old, you ought to die."

It seemed he had finally returned to his senses. Laughter trickled from all around the inn at his grumbling.

Black Sand had relaxed completely as well. He let out a quiet laugh and asked,

“Elder, have you come to your senses?”

The old man answered.

“Who told a little bastard like you he could use *hao*-style speech with me? Are you from the Lower District Sect or something?”[935]

“…”

“And why are you holding my wrist? You trying to get fresh with me?”

“H-Hey, you.”

“Are you letting go or not? I’ll count to three. One, two, three.”

Whoosh.

Before he knew what he was doing, Black Sand had released the old man’s wrist. The sudden turn of events had left him completely bewildered.

What the hell is this old man?

The stream of coarse curses and rapid-fire words had made his body move on its own.

The man was clearly nothing more than a deranged old fool who did not know a single martial art, yet Black Sand felt as though he had been bewitched.

“Ha-ha-ha-ha! He got you good!”

The Human Butcher burst into raucous laughter. He had already resented Black Sand acting as their leader despite being a step below him in martial arts.

Seeing Black Sand humiliated by a senile old man was deeply satisfying.

“That old man has quite a mouth on him. He gave me a good laugh, so I suppose I’ll let him live.”

But the satisfied smile on the Human Butcher’s face did not last long.

A single sentence from the old man wiped it away.

“You worthless bastard… Don’t you have a mother and father?”

“…!”

The inn plunged into icy silence.

Who were Black Sand and the Human Butcher?

They were major figures who dominated the Northern Gaoyuan. Their forces were formidable, but each of them was also a Peak master capable of crushing an average mounted-bandit group with ease.

They commanded respect and fear in equal measure, yet the old man had carved them apart with a few words.

---

[935] *Hao*-style speech is a semi-formal Korean speech level; its name sets up the pun on the Lower District Sect’s Korean name, *Haomun*.

"One's a sodomite from the Lower District Sect. One grew up without parents and has only half a tongue. And as for the other two…"

The old man glanced at Temur and Chinggen, both of whom wore their hair in queues,[936] then sighed.

"You're still young, but your foreheads are already bare. How pitiful."

No one had the energy left to be surprised. Amid the atmosphere of shock and horror, the old man clicked his tongue. Then he noticed the food spread out before the four men, and his eyes widened.

"Well, damn. You've laid out one hell of a feast. I was hungry, too. Perfect."

No one had time to stop him.

The old man grabbed a well-roasted duck by one leg and ripped into it.

"Would you look at how tender that meat is? Melts right on the tongue."

Crunch, crunch.

After devouring both legs in the blink of an eye, he abruptly held out a chunk of meat to the Human Butcher, who was trembling with rage and shock.

"You're still young. Why are you shaking like that? Don't go wasting away from weakness—eat this. I don't like dry breast meat. No, I can't eat it. My teeth are bad."

Crack.

Everyone in the inn heard the same sound.

It was the sound of the last thread of the Human Butcher's reason snapping—and the death knell of a man.

"You goddamn old bastard!"

The next moment, the Human Butcher, beside himself with rage, shot upward like lightning. At the same time, crimson Sword Energy poured from the horse-chopping sword in his hand and swept across everything in front of him.

"What the hell!"

"Move!"

Kaboom!

Temur and Chinggen had barely thrown themselves aside when a thunderous explosion shook the inn.

Hundreds—thousands—of wooden fragments flew in every direction as a cloud of dust billowed through the air.

"Die! Die! Die!"

The sight sent chills down the onlookers' spines. Judging by the madness pouring from the Human Butcher, the old man could not possibly have survived. There would not be so much as a scrap of flesh left.

"How dare a senile old man—! Aaaaargh!"

[936] A queue is a hairstyle with the front of the head shaved and the remaining hair worn in a long braid.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

A relentless storm of Sword Energy continued to pour forth. The Human Butcher finally withdrew his horse-chopping sword after the time it takes to drink a cup of tea.

“Huff… huff…”

Breathing heavily, he swung his weapon through the air. The resulting pressure scattered the dust cloud, revealing ruins that had been half reduced to powder.

Just as everyone had expected, the old man was nowhere to be seen.

“He was the bravest man I’ve ever seen.”

“Farewell, elder.”

“Why did he have to provoke the Human Butcher…?”

“As expected of those Han Chinese. They’re unbelievably savage.”

The more than two hundred mounted bandits and nomads were whispering among themselves when—

Crunch, crunch. Gulp. Guh-hup!

“…”

“…”

“…”

At first, they were simply dumbfounded.

What kind of clueless bastard would be eating and drinking at a time like this?

But it took only an instant for their disbelief to turn to shock.

“T-The old man! The old man’s alive!”

“What? Where?”

“Behind us! It came from behind us!”

Someone shouted.

Then a sharp, clear voice followed, making everyone doubt their own ears.

“Young people these days have no manners. Is my name ‘old man’? Am I your friend?”

“W-Whoa!”

“That does it. I’ll teach you bastards some manners today.”

Thud-thud-thud! Whoosh!

The mounted bandits and nomads filling the inn went flying one after another.

Every one of them was hurled aside with mangled limbs and smashed faces. The sight made the leaders break out in cold sweats.

W-What is this?

How did he get over there?

I didn’t even see him move.

A master.

A master capable of deceiving the eyes of Peak masters like them.

Black Sand, Temur, and Chinggen went rigid. Only one man charged toward the old man.

“You goddamn old bastard!”

The Human Butcher had already lost all reason. Nothing could hold him back now.

The old man saw him barreling forward and frowned.

“You’re…”

“That’s right! It’s me! This time, I’ll kill you for sure!”

“So you’re the one without parents.”

“Graaaargh!”

Whoooosh!

Mount Tai Presses Down on the Crown.[937]

The horse-chopping blade, its crimson Sword Energy blazing, was about to split the crown of the old man’s head. The old man swung something.

Slice! Thud!

Time seemed to stop.

Not a single breath could be heard. Everyone stared in disbelief.

The horse-chopping sword had been cut in half.

And in the old man’s hand was something tiny.

“T-That’s…”

For the first time, sanity returned to the Human Butcher’s eyes. He stared at the old man in fear and astonishment.

“…A chicken bone?”

“No part of a chicken goes to waste. The meat tastes good, the bones make a fine broth when you simmer them long enough, and sometimes they’re even handy for wielding Sword Energy.”

Sword Energy wielded through a chicken bone.

The Human Butcher had never seen or heard of anything so bizarre.

He understood instinctively.

A master. A Supreme Peak master. Someone I could never hope to fight.

The old man looked at the stunned Human Butcher and muttered,

“Come to think of it… You’re a vicious one. The stench of blood is pouring off your entire body.”

Every word sent goose bumps crawling across the Human Butcher’s skin. He had lived his entire life as a predator, yet now he was no more than a rat before a tiger.

“Can’t leave someone like you running around…”

[937] Mount Tai is a mountain in China’s Shandong Province and one of the Five Sacred Mountains of China.

A sudden chill swept through the Human Butcher. His teeth chattered at the deadly aura seeping from the old man's entire body.

"P-Please."

"Hm?"

"Please spare me. Please…"

Tears ran down his cheeks. His trousers grew damp, and the horse-chopping sword slipped from his limp hand.

The Human Butcher had spent his life taking the lives of others. No one could believe they were now watching him beg for his own.

The old man stared at him for a moment, then spoke.

"Don't be afraid."

I'm safe. I'm alive! I escaped death!

The Human Butcher let out an involuntary sigh of relief.

That was when—

Thump.

A rough, wrinkled hand, its knuckles jutting sharply beneath the skin, pressed against his chest.

That was the end.

"…Huh?"

The world turned upside down along with his faint question. Blood poured from the seven orifices[938] of his fallen body and soaked the floor.

He said he'd spare me. Why?

As his vision dimmed and the sounds around him receded, he heard the old man speak.

"Don't be afraid. I'll send you off without pain."

The old man had told the truth.

There was no pain.

The Human Butcher.

A Peak master whose evil reputation had spread all the way to the Central Plains had died in a single move.

"Well, then…"

The old man addressed the people who had frozen in place.

"Where is this place?"

[938] The seven bodily openings are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

Chapter 163

"What? The Northern Gaoyuan? And there are only three days left until New Year's Day?"

"Yes."

"Well, now."

The old man fell silent. Before him, the three leaders and more than two hundred of their men knelt respectfully, hanging on his every word.

"Is that really true?"

"W-We're certain."

"How could we possibly dare lie to your face?"

"…I see."

The old man's expression darkened at their desperate excuses.

He knew what they were saying was true. He had only wanted to deny it, if only a little—the fact that he was growing old.

So I was out of it for seven days and nights. Seven days and nights… It's getting longer.

It was because of the infirmities of old age.

He had first noticed the strange symptoms more than twenty years ago. While cultivating, he had felt his essence, qi, and spirit falling out of alignment and realized that time had finally caught up with him.

He was already nearing a hundred. He did not fear death, but he had no desire to be remembered as a senile old man.

Even after all that effort…

He had reached his limit. The curse of time could not be held back even by two jiazi[939] of internal energy or the Force of a Supreme Peak master.

He had managed to stave off the infirmities of old age for twenty years. He should be satisfied with that alone. The old man forced himself to cast aside his bitterness.

"Pour me a drink."

"Um, the wine has gone cold, so we're preparing a fresh batch."

At Black Sand's cautious reply, the old man clicked his tongue.

"How long will that take? Never mind. Bring me the cold wine."

"Yes."

Who would dare argue with him? At a glance from Black Sand, two burly mounted bandits hauled over a wine jar, grunting with effort.

The enormous jar, tall enough to reach a man's chest, sloshed with half-cooled mare's-milk wine.

[939] A jiazi is one sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar; two jiazi are 120 years.

"Tsk, tsk. Young men these days are so weak. Don't you feed your men?"

"H-How could we not?"

"Then why are they struggling so much? Good grief. I can't stand watching this."

The old man sprang to his feet and snatched the jar away. Weighing several hundred geun[940] at the very least, it rose effortlessly in one hand.

It was almost impossible to believe such strength could come from a body reduced to little more than skin and bones. Black Sand wanted to gouge out his own eyes.

I must have been insane. I thought a monster like that was nothing more than a senile old man.

At least he had watched his words. The Human Butcher had swung his sword around while calling the man an old geezer, and look how horribly he had died.

Black Sand had no desire to meet the same end, bleeding from all seven orifices.[941]

"Elder! I'll do it!"

"Don't call me elder. Sit down and stop talking nonsense."

"No, no. Mare's-milk wine tastes best when it's piping hot. I'll heat it myself…"

"Piping hot, you say?"

Black Sand fell speechless.

The next moment, tremendous heat burst from the wine jar.

It came from the old man's hand gripping the jar.

White flames that made them feel suffocated and sent goose bumps crawling over their skin at the mere sight instantly heated the jar and warmed the mare's-milk wine.

"T-That's…"

"S-Samadhi True Fire?"

Temur, Chinggen, and the more than two hundred underlings were stunned by the sight before them.

The three leaders were particularly shocked.

What the hell?

He's using Samadhi True Fire on a wine jar that size?

That's an unbelievable amount of internal energy. Who is this old man?

Samadhi True Fire was a flame produced by burning internal energy. Any Peak master with sufficiently profound internal energy could use it without much difficulty.

However, the flames were weak compared to the enormous amount of internal energy they consumed, making them hopelessly inefficient in actual combat.

"Bring me a bowl. A big one."

---

[940] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Several hundred geun would weigh at least about 120 kg (264 lb).

[941] The seven orifices are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

But this old man was different.

The heat they had felt, though momentary, had been tremendous. If he wished, he seemed capable not only of harming people but of melting steel.

His martial arts and internal energy have already reached a transcendent realm.

It isn't only the Samadhi True Fire. His internal energy itself is overwhelmingly powerful Scorching Yang Qi.

Keep your mouth shut. One wrong word and… you're dead.

The three men swallowed hard and hurried about like waiters attending an honored guest.

"Allow me to pour you a drink."

"Bring meat! Meat!"

"Just tear off the legs!"

Black Sand, the Squad Leader of the Black Sand Band—known across the steppe as a harbinger of death—poured the mare's-milk wine. The two tribal chieftains, descendants of the Great Khan and commanders of hundreds of mounted warriors, circled the table, tearing off only the tender leg meat and presenting it to the old man.

It was a sight even gold could not buy.

"Mm. This is why rude bastards need a good beating. They only learn manners after someone teaches them a lesson."

"You're absolutely right, elder."

The old man, who had been washing down carefully stripped meat with mare's-milk wine, paused.

"Elder?"

"Y-Yes. Did I make some kind of mistake?"

"You're making me sound old. Like some old man who could drop dead at any moment."

Yes. You really do look like you're about to drop dead.

Black Sand barely swallowed the words before they escaped. His opponent was a peerless master whose realm he could not even begin to fathom. He had to stay on the old man's good side somehow.

"Then, big brother…"

"Do I look like a pushover?"

"I-I'm sorry!"

Bam!

Without another word, Black Sand slammed his forehead against the floor. He wanted to die. The man hated "elder" because it made him sound old, but apparently "big brother" made him sound like a pushover. What the hell was Black Sand supposed to call him?

The old man gave the prostrated Black Sand a light kick.

“Get up.”

“Yes, sir!”

“You two with the scraped foreheads as well.”

Whoosh!

Temur and Chinggen, who had been diligently stripping meat from the bones, rushed over at the speed of light and knelt.

Only after taking a long drink of mare’s-milk wine did the old man finally speak.

“So, what kind of bastards are you?”

Mounted bandits. And nomads who were little different from mounted bandits.

They had no idea what would happen if they told the truth to an old man who was clearly a senior master of the orthodox faction.

Just as the three desperately exchanged glances—

Smack! Smack! Smack!

“Ghk!”

“Gasp!”

“Argh!”

The old man struck each of them on the head with a knuckle at a speed too fast to see, then glared.

“You goddamn bastards. An adult asks you a question, and all you do is roll your eyes at each other?”

“I-I’m sorry, elder.”

“I told you not to call me elder. Are you performing some ritual to pray for my death? Huh?”

Smack!

Black Sand answered and got hit again for his trouble. He felt tears welling up. He was over fifty, and all his subordinates were watching him…

“Oldest one first. Answer me.”

Black Sand gazed at the old man with watery eyes and opened his mouth.

“I, that is… I roam the steppe with like-minded brothers, with our horses as companions…”

“So you’re a worthless mounted bandit. You loot, murder, and set fires every chance you get.”

“…”

The old man regarded Black Sand with utter contempt before turning away. Temur and Chinggen flinched and lowered their heads.

“You two call yourselves nomads, but you’re no different. Am I wrong?”

“N-No, sir.”

“You are absolutely right.”

“The only way you’re better than mounted bandits is that, although you loot and kill, at least you aren’t arsonists setting fire to everything in sight. Bastards who burn down other people’s homes deserve to be beaten to death!”

“…”

“…”

“…”

Wasn’t murder normally considered the gravest crime?

The three men tilted their heads at this strange distinction, only to be struck by another hail of blows.

Smack! Smack! Smack!

“Anyway, I have a general idea what sort of holes you crawled out of. What I want to know is how much influence you have around here.”

“Ow… What do you mean by influence?”

“Exactly what I said. Do you have any clout?”

Rubbing the tops of their heads, the three men answered carefully.

“If we join forces, there aren’t many who could stand against us.”

“Most of our people are spread across separate branch families, but if all our relatives gathered, we could easily make up dozens of tribes and still have people left over.”

“We share every piece of news from across the steppe.”

The old man’s eyes flashed at Chinggen’s final answer.

“Oh? That’s useful.”

Quick to read the situation, Chinggen realized the old man wanted information and immediately answered.

“If you need information, we’ll tell you anything you wish to know.”

“I’m looking for someone. I don’t know exactly where he is, but… he probably isn’t too far away. Can you find him?”

“Yes. If you could describe his appearance or any distinguishing features, it would be even easier.”

“Wait here.”

The old man pulled a crumpled sheet of xuan paper[942] from his robes. A fairly skilled artist appeared to have drawn it, and the face of the person he sought was clearly depicted.

“Will this do?”

Chinggen nodded without hesitation.

[942] Xuan paper is a traditional Chinese paper used for painting and calligraphy.

"Of course. With a portrait sketch as well, we should be able to start asking around immediately."

If they sent messengers in all directions and dispatched messenger eagles, they could learn the answer within fifteen days at the longest.

The steppe was vast, but no one could escape the eyes of the nomads.

Besides, every scrap of news about outsiders reaches my ears.

But Chinggen's confidence faltered at the old man's next words.

"He's a Peak master. He primarily uses a sword and palm techniques."

"…Did you say he's a Peak master?"

"Why? Doesn't that make things easier? He'll stand out wherever he goes, so you should find him quickly."

Chinggen struggled to speak.

"I-I'm sorry, but if he's a master of that level, my brothers would have noticed him long ago."

"Hmm. What do you two think?"

"I oversee a fairly wide territory myself, but I've never heard of such a master appearing."

"If Chinggen cannot find him, then neither can I."

After receiving similar answers from Black Sand and Temur, who had been sitting quietly with their shoulders hunched, the old man furrowed his brow.

"Damn that bastard. Making an old man go through all this trouble."

The three men's ears perked up at the bitterness in his mutter.

What circumstances could have driven an unidentified Supreme Peak master to search for someone personally? Especially while suffering from the infirmities of old age.

His son? Or his Disciple?

Judging by his attitude, the man had to be a blood relative or Disciple…

Black Sand felt his heart pounding. An old man standing at the end of his life was searching for someone while struggling to hold on to a mind that came and went.

Someone he had to meet before he died. A final lingering regret he had to resolve, even if it meant going to such lengths.

Could this be…?

Black Sand's thoughts raced. Perhaps he could turn the greatest crisis of his life into an opportunity.

His lips parted slightly, and Sound Transmission slipped out.

—Chinggen.

Despite the sudden Sound Transmission, Chinggen showed no reaction. As expected, he was a shrewd one.

—Are you listening? Answer me.

—Accept the old man's offer. Quickly!

—Impossible. I can't find the person he wants. If we succeed, we may earn a tremendous favor, but if we raise his hopes for nothing and fail, all we'll earn is his resentment. I have no intention of taking that risk. Nor do I want to become any more entangled with that old man.

—Find him.

—What?

—If you find him, you can obtain the old man's martial arts. Martial arts powerful enough to look down upon the entire world!

At that moment, Black Sand was utterly convinced. Whether the person was the old man's Disciple or his son, they had to find him. If they did…

We could steal not just one city, but the entire world!

He intended to blackmail a Supreme Peak master. Chinggen's lips trembled slightly as he grasped Black Sand's meaning.

—Are you insane? Greed has blinded you!

—No, it's entirely possible. You're too frightened of that old man to think clearly.

—Don't be ridiculous. Do you think he'll fall for a threat like that? He'll tear us apart before that happens!

—He's already an old man whose mind comes and goes because of his infirmities. First, we scour the surrounding area and find the bastard. Then we drag things out until the old man loses his mind again.

Even Black Sand thought it was a perfect plan. When the old man's mind was not clear, he was no different from a child.

They would wait for that moment, then subdue him. Through persuasion and threats, they would steal every bit of that powerful martial arts knowledge.

—What are you hesitating for? Accept already!

That was when an answer came.

"Yes, hurry up and accept. What are you waiting for?"

Black Sand froze.

The old man was staring at him with reddish, glowing eyes. Flames no one could possibly resist streamed from his dark, sunken pupils.

"Are you finished?"

"E-Elder."

"You aren't particularly bright, are you? You've already made me say the same thing three times."

Thud.

At that same instant, the old man's palm pierced Black Sand's abdomen. Scorching Yang Qi at its utmost burned his organs and seared his blood vessels.

"Didn't I tell you not to call me elder?"

Thump.

Black Sand collapsed as a charred lump. Chinggen closed his eyes as a voice drier than desert sand bored into his ears.

“I’ll be back in about a month.”

When Chinggen opened his eyes again, the old man was nowhere to be seen.

The old man clicked his tongue.

“Nothing has changed. Absolutely nothing has changed.”

The world he had returned to after so long was still the same. Evil men, righteous men, and those who belonged to neither side were all mixed together.

No matter who lived or died, someone always filled the empty space they left behind. The same was true of those mounted bandits. They had simply been unlucky.

“Speaking of which, the Northern Gaoyuan…”

“I certainly came a long way,” the old man muttered as he looked around.

The horizon stretched to the ends of the world. Here, where green grasslands and parched earth existed side by side, there was only one place for him to go.

I’ll leave this area to that nomad bastard and search Shanxi Province myself.

The old man began to walk. With every step, the landscape flashed past and the grasses bowed low.

His stride was leisurely, yet he moved as swiftly as a loosed arrow.

The arrow was bound for Datong, on the border between Shanxi and the Gaoyuan.

Chapter 164

SYSTEM

Status Window
Lv. 71 Jin Taekyung
Class: Peak Master
Fame: 2,400 (+250)
Titles: 5 (Title effects active)
- Returnee (All stats +10)
- Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi (All stats +15, Fame +200)
- Scion of a Prestigious Family (All stats +5, Fame +50)
- Gambler (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one combat)
- Intermediate Trainee (Training speed +20%)

Strength: 255 (+30)
Stamina: 207 (+30)
Agility: 250 (+30)
Intelligence: 40 (+30)
Charm: 40 (+30)
Internal Energy: 45 years
Toughness: 200 (+30)
Remaining Points: 70
- Distribute your remaining points.

I checked my Status Window more than ten times a day, but it still made me grin every time.

Who knew the four characters meaning “Peak Master” could make me this happy?

The System calls me a master. A Peak Master.

Only a few hours ago, the Class field had read First Rate Martial Artist. But now I was a Peak Master. Not just a martial artist, but a master.

I had become a genuine master, recognized even by the System.

And I’m already Level 71.

The rewards had been incredible.

Seven level-ups, a one-stage increase in both the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique and Qi Sense, and…

I even got something money couldn’t buy.

Open Inventory.

As soon as I entered the command in my mind, a familiar System notification chimed and a translucent holographic window appeared.

My Inventory was packed with all kinds of junk I had collected in the Murim, but my gaze went straight to one item.

Summon Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

Whoosh.

A heavy sphere suddenly popped into existence in midair. It was about the size of a bowling ball, its unpolished surface rough and jagged, with lumps jutting out in every direction.

At first glance, it looked like nothing more than a useless lump of metal or rock. But anyone who looked a little closer would recognize its true value.

Inspect Item.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Unprocessed Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron
Type: Material
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Master Artisan
Description: Ten-thousand-year-old cold iron is harder, sharper, and rarer than any other mineral in existence. Only a craftsman who has reached the level of Master Artisan will be able to work with this precious material.

"Now, this is the real deal."

Personally, I was happier about obtaining the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron than I was about leveling up. I was a Hunter and a martial artist. Everyone in this line of work dreamed of owning great equipment.

I had simply never had the means to make that dream a reality.

I had no money in the real world, and in the Murim, I didn't have a decent spear.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan's roots lay in sword techniques, not spear techniques.

Supply followed demand. Most of the family's members, from its lowest-ranking martial artists to its leadership, were swordsmen. Naturally, both the family's martial arts and the weapons in its armory favored swords by a wide margin.

If Jin Wikyung hadn't looked out for me, I might have ended up fighting with a cheap wooden or bamboo spear.

How many times had my guts twisted whenever I swung an iron spear while leaving the [Unnamed Sword], made from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, at my side?

But that humiliation is over now.

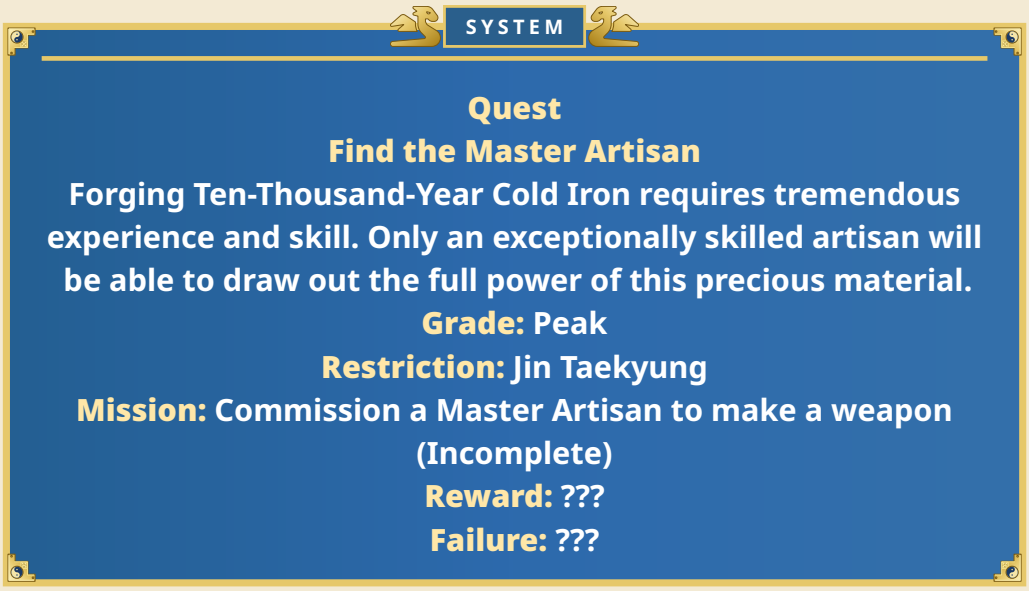
I had obtained the finest mineral in the world. Now I could have a weapon of my own made from it.

Of course, there was one prerequisite.

The Quest I had just received was related to that.

Inspect Quest.

Ding.



I smiled contentedly and closed the Quest Window.

Of course. I can't entrust something as valuable as Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron to just anyone.

Even without the Quest, I would have looked into it myself.

Just as a famed sword only revealed its true brilliance in the hands of a master, the same was true of a precious material like Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

Although the Quest was graded Peak, the mission itself didn't seem particularly difficult.

Finding someone shouldn't take long.

Surely there had to be at least one Master Artisan in this enormous land.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had branches throughout Shanxi. If I asked Jin Wikyung to send out word, we would soon know where to find one.

And if that doesn't work, I can ask the Lower District Sect.

I even had a powerful connection in Wolhwa. With eyes and ears planted throughout Shanxi Province, finding someone like that would be a piece of cake for her.

Whatever it takes, I'm completing this Quest before I leave.

A month in the Murim was only three hours in the modern world.

I still had plenty of time.

“Hehehe. A spear made from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. A spear made from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron…”

Just as I was grinning from ear to ear—

Bang!

The door blew apart with a deafening crash. Someone rushed in like lightning, charging toward me with both arms spread wide.

“Youngest!”

Yep. I knew it would be you.

I let out a deep sigh and asked Jin Wikyung, “What’s going on?”

“What do you mean, what’s going on? I heard the wonderful news that you broke through the wall and rushed here at once!”

“…How did you hear about that?”

It had only happened an hour or two ago, but the speed of the information network was no joke. Had this guy attached a Familiar to me or something?

As I stared at him in bewilderment, I spotted Hyuk Mujin standing in front of the blown-open doorway with a proud smile. He rubbed beneath his nose and said, “Shouldn’t such wonderful news be delivered first by one’s closest aide?”

“…”

Not a Familiar. A Hyuk-miliar.

That bastard had definitely used my name to score points with Jin Wikyung.

“Waaah! Our youngest broke through the wall! He reached the Peak realm!”

Sure enough, Hyuk Mujin quickly cut in.

“Lesser Family Head, I stood guard over him!”

“Thank you. Truly, thank you. Your contribution was enormous!”

“Not at all. As your right arm, I merely did what I was supposed to do. I had not a shred of selfish intent. However, I noticed that the position of Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion is still vacant…”

“It’s yours without question! No, you’ll be the next Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

“W-Whaaat? Is that really true?”

“…”

Of course it wasn’t, you dumbass.

Did it make any sense to appoint someone Family Head just because he had stood guard? Besides, all that bastard had actually done was snore.

But the two men, blinded by joy and power, were already out of their minds.

“Hyuk Mujin. You said your name was Hyuk Mujin, right?”

“Yes, Lesser Family Head!”

“Our Mujin can do whatever he wants! Become Family Head! Smash the Nine Sects and One Gang! Smash the world!”

"Smash!"

"...What are you smashing, you lunatics?"

The future of the Jin Family of Taiyuan looked bleak.

Once the commotion died down, Jin Wikyung finally managed to calm himself and looked at me with moist eyes.

"Your brother is proud of you."

"I'm proud of you too, Captain. But if I hadn't stood guard over you..."

"Mujin, let's keep quiet unless you want your pot cracked. And by 'pot,' I mean your head."

"Yes, sir."

Hyuk Mujin, now sporting a lump on his forehead, answered at once. As expected, he only listened after getting hit.

"Your useless older brother couldn't even look after you properly, and yet you grew up so well all on your own. Sniff."

"..."

Look at this human weapon getting all sentimental.

Whenever Jin Wikyung acted like this, I was grateful that this world had no social media. If it did, a post tagging every member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan would have gone up on Outstagram.

Complete with a teary-eyed selfie and hashtags.

> #JinFamilyofTaiyuan #UselessOlderBrother #OurYoungestIsAPeakMaster #KeepYourChinUpToday
>
> └ **Wolhwa:** Oh my! Young Master Jin? Congratulations!
>
> └ **Cheongpung:** Wow, I've never clicked Like before!
>
> └ **Wipeng:** Don't lie.
>
> └ **Hyuk Mujin:** I stood guard over him.
>
> └ **Jin Mukyung:** Is this what you call a country?[943]
>
> └ **Zhu Bao:** An autograph, please.

Imagining the reactions from countless Shanxi Province celebrities made my vision swim.

I hurriedly pushed the horrifying thought from my mind and tried to soothe Jin Wikyung.

[943] "Is this what you call a country?" is a Korean expression of exasperation at a perceived injustice or absurdity, often used sarcastically.

“Please stop crying. How old are you?”

“Sniff. How did my immature youngest brother grow into such a fine man?”

Jin Wikyung gazed at me with a mixture of emotion and pride, then wiped the corners of his eyes with his sleeve.

“No, this won’t do. I need to go right now and…”

“You’re not planning to write ‘Jin Taekyung has become a Peak Master’ on a gigantic banner like last time, are you?”

“Gasp.”

“…”

I knew it. Judging by everything Jin Wikyung had done until now, there was no way he would let this opportunity pass. I had to make myself perfectly clear.

“Don’t do anything like that. It’s cringe.”

“Cringe? What does that mean?”

“It means embarrassing.”

Jin Wikyung looked shocked.

“Are you saying you’re embarrassed by me? By your own brother?”

“No, that’s not what I…”

This was driving me insane.

Before I could answer, Hyuk Mujin, who had been sitting quietly with his shoulders hunched, suddenly cut in with a baffled look.

“Huh? Captain, you usually like getting attention.”

“When have I ever?”

“You don’t? If I remember correctly, you seemed to love it. When we returned from the Mount Heng Sword Sect, you stood at the very front and waved like crazy.”

“…Ahem.”

If he had made that up, I would have punched him. But it was true, so I had nothing to say.

I quietly avoided Hyuk Mujin’s gaze and replied, “That was different. I had my reasons.”

“What reasons?”

“There were reasons. You don’t need to know.”

“Wow, there he goes again.”

I ignored Hyuk Mujin’s muttering and turned back to Jin Wikyung.

“Anyway, we’re not doing anything like that. The attention I’m getting now is more than enough.”

“Hmm. If that’s truly what you want…”

Jin Wikyung couldn't hide his disappointment, but I was so firm that he reluctantly nodded. That let me breathe a sigh of relief.

What's the point of advertising that I became a Peak Master? I'll only attract a whole swarm of flies.

There had been a time when I would have risked my life for Fame, but not anymore.

If anything, Fame now felt ominous.

Why does it feel like the higher my Fame gets, the stronger the people it attracts become?

My life's motto was to live a quiet, long life. Of course, living large and long would be even better, but people who tried that rarely had peaceful lives.

Constantly fighting battles where my life hung in the balance had also left me exhausted in both body and mind.

I need to make at least the bare minimum of preparations.

I planned to make one hell of a spear from the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron and hone my martial arts. To do that, I absolutely needed Jin Wikyung's help.

"Could you do me one favor?"

Jin Wikyung was not the sort of person to refuse. He nodded confidently.

"Say the word."

"I need information."

"Information? About what, exactly?"

"Two things. First, the whereabouts of a Master Artisan skilled enough to work with Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. Second, news about the Fire King."

"The first is understandable, but the Fire King… Surely you aren't thinking of learning *that*?"

That referred to the Flame Divine Palm.

I had never told Jin Wikyung directly, but he already knew everything.

It made sense. The Flame Divine Palm was the Fire King's signature martial art, and touching it carelessly was no different from holding a bomb that could put the entire family at risk. I had already assumed Jin Mukyung would have reported it to Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head, long ago.

"Taekyung."

Hearing the concern in his voice, I waved a hand.

"I'm not planning to learn it right away. I just want to confirm whether the Fire King is alive or dead before I decide."

"Hmm."

After a brief silence, Jin Wikyung spoke.

"Will you promise me one thing? Before you do that, you'll consult with me first."

"Yes."

“Then that’s settled.”

Jin Wikyung nodded decisively and rose from his seat.

“Information about the Fire King may take some time, but I can tell you about the first matter right now.”

Already? That was the Jin Family of Taiyuan for you. They seemed to have a handle on almost everything.

The progress was much faster than I had expected. My butt practically itched with impatience to go find the man immediately.

“He must be nearby?”

“Yes. He has been living in seclusion, hidden from everyone. Even our family only learned of his existence recently.”

“And his skill?”

“I guarantee that even if you scoured every inch under heaven, he would rank among the ten best.”

If Jin Wikyung could speak that confidently, then the man’s skill was beyond question.

A Master Artisan capable of handling Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. I had found him much faster than expected.

“I’ll go back and confirm it once more, then send word. Now, get some rest. Ho ho, you broke through the wall. A Peak Master at twenty!”

Jin Wikyung disappeared with a broad grin. Hyuk Mujin opened his mouth, looking as though his curiosity might kill him.

“What is it?”

“Hm? What is what?”

“What on earth is that ‘thing’ related to the Fire King?”

“Oh, that? The Flame Divine Palm.”

“The Flame Divine Palm?”

He looked utterly bewildered. Of course. He wasn’t a martial arts expert like Jin Mukyung, so it was only natural that he didn’t know.

“Yeah. The Flame Divine Palm. It’s the Fire King’s signature martial art.”

“…What?”

“Why are you so surprised?”

“H-How did you get it? No, before that, is it really all right to tell me something this important?”

Despite the shock and confusion on his face, I kindly answered him.

“Yeah. You even saw it yourself.”

“…What?”

“What do you mean, ‘what’? You’ve seen the Flame Divine Palm martial arts manual before. No, you didn’t just see it—you almost ended up owning it.”

“I did?”

“Yeah. Don’t you remember? Before the battle at Eight Spring Gorge, we stayed behind as the rear party. With those Samdo Sect guys—Gwak Jun or whatever his name was, and the others.”

Hyuk Mujin sank into thought, and his mouth slowly fell open.

“Don’t tell me it was that thing back then…”

“That’s the one. The thing you refused when I told you to take it.”

“…!”

“Whew. Good thing I didn’t give it to you back then.”

Hyuk Mujin’s face twisted miserably.

Chapter 165

Knock, knock, knock.

The information I had asked Jin Wikyung for arrived sooner than expected.

What surprised me was the identity of the messenger.

“Huh? What brings you here?”

“My lord said he had a letter that needed delivering, so I came.”

“You came personally?”

The man who had come to deliver Jin Wikyung’s letter was none other than Wipeng.

He stared silently at me for a while before tossing out a single remark.

“So it was true. You really crossed the wall.”

From a low hill, one could not see what lay atop a high peak. But someone standing on that peak could see everything below.

The same was true of Wipeng now.

An accomplished Peak master himself, he recognized the change in me at a glance. He regarded me with a mixture of awe and disbelief.

“How is such a thing possible?”

“Uh…”

What was I supposed to say to that?

Most people believed the ridiculous rumors about me without question, but Wipeng was different.

Along with the brothers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, he was one of the very few people who knew the truth.

It really is absurd.

A Third Rate thug had become a Peak master in only two or three months.

Even the most open-minded person would find that impossible to comprehend. Perhaps that was precisely why people believed the rumors.

Because those actually sound more plausible.

When I hesitated, unable to answer, Wipeng waved a hand. He was probably mindful of Hyuk Mujin listening beside us as well.

“We should save that discussion for another time.”

Still looking troubled, Wipeng pulled a letter from inside his robes. It contained the information I had asked Jin Wikyung to find.

As I accepted and unfolded it, Wipeng began to explain.

“His name is Jang Taebo. Until a little over ten years ago, he belonged to the Ironcraft Guild.”

“The Ironcraft Guild?”

“It is a guild based in Hubei. Most of its members are skilled craftsmen rather than martial artists.”

In other words, it was a blacksmiths’ guild.

I asked the most important question.

“How skilled is he?”

“He was the Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild.”

“Oh.”

That brief answer told me everything I needed to know.

If he had risen to become Guild Leader in the Ironcraft Guild, which was packed with skilled craftsmen, then he was practically a Master Artisan already.

I carefully read through the information about Jang Taebo.

“He lives fairly close by, too?”

“In a village near Jeongyang. Do you remember? The place where we received Prince Shangshan’s invitation…”

“Oh, there.”

Had it been about fifteen days ago? That was where I had marched with the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s elites like a victorious general.

Hyuk Mujin, who had been listening quietly beside us, spoke up.

“If we don’t slacken the reins, we should arrive around sunset.”

“Right?”

“Yes.”

“So what are you still doing here?”

“…What?”

“Go get ready to leave. Set aside two strong horses and pack some food for the road.”

“Wait, what… Am I a servant?”

“There’s no high or low in honest work. Are you looking down on servants now? Should I call every servant in the Jin Family of Taiyuan and give you a lecture?”

“Oh, fine! I get it, so stop already!”

Unable to endure my nagging any longer, Hyuk Mujin grumbled his way out of the room. Wipeng clicked his tongue.

“Your subordinate’s attitude is terribly insolent.”

“…”

Well, from where I was standing, he wasn’t exactly one to talk.

The way you constantly hounded people to work whenever you had the chance was enough to make even a mother-in-law slap someone across the face with a

bundle of kimchi.[944]

Look at this hypocrite.

Oblivious to my thoughts, Wipeng continued.

“In any case, you must return by noon tomorrow at the latest. You have not forgotten that New Year’s Day is in two days, have you?”

“Ah, right.”

The entire Jin Family of Taiyuan was already in an uproar over it. I had nearly grown used to the sight of servants and maids rushing around in a frenzy.

That was only natural. This was a grand banquet that would last at least three days, not some event that would end in a single day.

It is a pretty big deal.

It was an occasion to reaffirm the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s position as the ruler of Shanxi Province.

With so many guests arriving, everyone in the family was working day and night to ensure that nothing went wrong.

Everyone except me, of course.

“Do you really think I’ll be late? It’s only half a day away at most.”

Wipeng’s eyes narrowed.

“This is an important occasion, so I trust you will conduct yourself appropriately.”

“Your eyes say you don’t trust me at all.”

“That is a misunderstanding. A misunderstanding.”

“I’m just going to ask him for one favor and come straight back, so don’t worry.”

“Given the Third Young Master’s track record, I cannot help but worry.”

“…”

Trouble did seem to follow me wherever I went, so he wasn’t entirely wrong.

But I was a full-fledged Peak master now. I was far too grown-up to be treated like a little kid playing by the water.

“Even if I look like this—”

“I trust you were not about to say, ‘I’m a Peak master now, so stop treating me like a child by the water.‘”

Was he a ghost or something? I hurriedly swallowed the rest of my words.

“Of course not.”

“In Murim, no one knows what awaits them even a single step ahead. And be respectful toward Jang Taebo—Guild Leader Jang. The Ironcraft Guild has close ties with the Nine Sects and One Gang,[945] and its current Guild Leader is Jang Taebo’s Disciple. It would be unwise to offend him.”

---

[944] A kimchi slap is a melodramatic Korean television trope in which someone strikes another person with kimchi.

[945] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations in the story.

“My hobby is filial piety, and my specialty is respecting the elderly.”

“I can still vividly recall the Third Young Master hurling every imaginable obscenity at the Head Elder.”

“Hey, that was different!”

“Of course. I was merely pointing it out. Why are you getting so angry? Do you think I’m a pushover now that you’re a Peak master?”

Look at those eyes. He looked ready to challenge me to a duel.

Of course, if we actually fought, I would still be the one getting beaten. I casually changed the subject.

“But aren’t you busy? You must have a lot of work piled up.”

Wipeng frowned.

“I do need to return as soon as possible. There has been suspicious activity near Datong.”

“Datong… the northern Gaoyuan?”

“I hear the mounted bandits are prowling around again.”

“How long has it even been since the Red Wind Band was crushed?”

“Precisely.”

Rubbing his dry eyes, Wipeng rose from his seat.

“Then I will be going. I suppose we will see each other again at noon tomorrow.”

Wipeng placed pointed emphasis on *noon tomorrow* right to the end. He was about to leave when he suddenly stopped.

“And there is something I have been meaning to ask…”

“Yes?”

Looking utterly bewildered, Wipeng pointed at the badly mangled door.

“What happened to this? It can’t have been more than a few days since it was completed.”

“Who do you think did it?”

The same person you, I, and everyone else would suspect, of course.

Wipeng appeared to realize who the culprit was. He let out a long sigh and left the room. Judging by the murderous set of his shoulders, he was clearly going to lay into Jin Wikyung.

“Well, I should get going too.”

I was on my way to have my own custom weapon made. My steps felt light enough to fly.

“Are you ready?”

In front of the stables, Hyuk Mujin was inspecting the saddles. He answered curtly.

"Not yet."

"Still?"

"Yes."

What was taking him so long?

When I approached, I saw the horse's flanks were covered in bundles. One sniff told me they were all filled with food. They were still warm, as though they had only recently been cooked.

"What's all this?"

"What do you think? Food."

"You think I'm asking because I don't know that? Huh? Why did you pack so much? Some jerky and water would've been enough."

Hyuk Mujin gave me a wounded look.

"I didn't pack it."

"If you didn't, who did?"

"Who do you think?"

Hyuk Mujin pointed behind me. A young man came racing toward us, weighed down by bundle after bundle.

The moment Cheongpung spotted me, his face lit up.

"Oh! Hello, Benefactor!"

"Ah… hello."

Sure, hello. But why are you here?

I turned a demanding look on Hyuk Mujin, and he began to explain.

"I ran into him on the way to the stables. He said he wanted to come along. What was I supposed to do?"

Cheongpung shouted enthusiastically.

"Benefactor! Take me with you! I want to go on a trip too!"

"This isn't a trip."

"Oh, really? I heard we were leaving today and coming back tomorrow…"

Did going somewhere today and returning tomorrow automatically make it a trip?

When I explained that I was going to meet a blacksmith in Jeongyang, Cheongpung's eyes lit up.

"Wow! A blacksmith!"

Hyuk Mujin and I spoke at the same time.

"You've never seen a blacksmith before, have you?"

"This must be your first time seeing a blacksmith."

"Yes, that's right! How did you know?"

"…"

"…"

It was more surprising that he didn't know.

Anyone who had spent even a single day with Cheongpung would understand exactly how I felt.

"Anyway, please take me with you."

"Well, I don't mind if you come along, but…"

"Wow!"

"Let people finish speaking, you idiot."

Ugh, this was exhausting. *Was this what extrovert energy felt like?*

Already feeling tired, I leaped onto my saddle. I also made sure to remove the securely tied food bundles ahead of time.

One dropped to the ground with a thud, and Cheongpung screamed.

"Ah! That's five-spice pork!"

"Why did you pack five-spice pork? I told you we'd be back soon!"

"No! My five-spice pork!"

"…Fuck."

It wasn't even mine.

Cheongpung insisted on gathering every last bundle, then grinned.

"Now let's go!"

I really do want to go. Just without you.

Clicking my tongue inwardly, I took hold of the reins and set off.

Then I had to listen to him chewing behind me until the sun went down.

Winter days were short.

As the sun vanished beyond the plateau's horizon, a dry voice slipped between the huge man's lips.

"It is time."

No sooner had he finished speaking than hundreds of silhouettes stirred in the darkness.

Draped in the hides of all manner of beasts, they mounted their horses, armed with curved sabers, sandalwood bows, and lances.

Within moments, a cavalry force of some four hundred riders had formed before the huge man. His parched voice rang out once more.

"Our task is simple."

His eyes gleamed dangerously. The veins bulging along his forearms and the breath steaming from his lips made him look like a wild beast.

"To kill and trample."

Low laughter rose here and there.

Their leader had given them permission to run wild. The roughly four hundred mounted bandits of the Heavenly Wind Band trembled with excitement.

The sight brought a satisfied smile to the huge man's face.

At last, I can do this properly.

The plan devised by his sworn elder brother, Black Sand, was brilliant.

Of course, what he liked most was that he only had to slaughter and plunder the enemies before him without thinking.

His role was the most important—and the simplest.

My blood is boiling.

These men were nothing like the ragtag forces of the Red Wind Band and the other dregs they had scraped together from far and wide.

They had eaten from the same pot and fought side by side for over a decade. They were seasoned elites, veterans of a hundred battles.

Heh heh. Just wait. Jin Family of Taiyuan or not, I'll trample every last one of you.

A thunderous roar erupted from the Heavenly Wind Band Leader's mouth.

"Go! Kill and plunder them all! Slaughter and burn everything in sight!"

"Waaaaah!"

"Let's go!"

The roughly four hundred mounted bandits, wild with excitement, had just turned their horses south when—

"You goddamn sons of bitches. What the hell do you think you're burning?"

A diminutive figure emerged with a sharp, ringing voice.

The unidentified old man's hand shone a blinding white.

Chapter 166

Old Man Jang's daily routine was simple: eat, sleep, and shit.

Every now and then, he visited a pleasure house or an inn for a drink, or sat in on a gambling game and played dominoes, but he spent most of his time at home.

By now, the villagers had grown accustomed to him. They would sometimes ask,

"Don't you get lonely?"

But Old Man Jang's answer was always firm.

"Don't talk nonsense."

People whispered that the solitary old man only said that out of pride, but he meant every word.

Life couldn't be more comfortable.

He slept when he was tired, ate when he was hungry, and shit when he needed to.

Some might mock him for living like a beast, but Old Man Jang had more than earned the right.

No—he felt even that was insufficient.

After the life I've lived.

He had spent an entire jiazi[946] before vats of boiling molten iron.

Once he started something, he had to see it through to the end. He had forgotten people and love alike. The anvil and hammer had been his friends and lovers.

I lived like a man possessed.

Then one day, he came to his senses and found that his hair had turned white and his vision had grown dim.

He had become one of the finest smiths under heaven and the Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild, but that was all.

No matter how many times he brought down his hammer, he could not fill the emptiness in his heart.

In the end, he decided to retire. And so Jang Taebo, the Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild, became Old Man Jang.

"Grandpa!"

"Uh, hm?"

Old Man Jang jerked out of his reverie. He had been squatting in the yard, staring blankly into space.

A little boy from the neighboring house was looking at him with enormous eyes.

"What are you thinking about?"

"I was thinking that if you used polite speech, I might give you a piece of candy."

"What are you thinking about, Grandpa?"

[946] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

"…What a sly little brat. Here."

"Tank you!"

Old Man Jang watched the boy busily suck on the candy.

He had known the child since he was a newborn. At first, the boy had been a nuisance, constantly clinging to him and calling him Grandpa. Then, at some point, Old Man Jang had found himself carrying snacks around for him.

Well, this isn't so bad either.

For a blunt and prickly old man like him, the boy was his only real conversation partner.

Looking at the child sometimes made him wonder what it might have been like to have a family of his own.

"Would you like another one?"

"Yeah, yeah!"

"Ahem. Polite speech."

"Yes!"

"Eat them slowly so you don't ruin your teeth. Understand?"

"Yeah!"

"…That polite speech didn't last long."

After licking two pieces of candy clean in the blink of an eye, the boy suddenly spoke.

"Oh, right. Grandpa."

"What is it?"

"What's your name?"

"You should ask an elder's name more respectfully… No, never mind. Why do you suddenly want to know?"

"Hmm, I was just curious."

"Hmm."

"I asked Mom and Dad too, but they said they didn't know your name. Nobody knows."

Though he had settled here more than ten years ago, Old Man Jang had never revealed his name to anyone.

He had been worried that flies might start buzzing around him. No—mere flies would have been a blessing.

Skilled smiths were needed everywhere, especially by Murim sects whose members would stake their lives on their weapons. If his identity became known, his remaining years would be anything but peaceful.

"Grandpa, aren't you going to tell me?"

Old Man Jang looked into the boy's large, innocent eyes.

Well, it should be safe to tell him a little.

He was too young to understand what any of it meant. Besides, a few more pieces of candy would distract him, and he would soon forget.

Old Man Jang only had to conceal enough to keep his identity hidden.

“I’ll tell you one character of my name. It’s Bo.”

“Your family name is Jang, so… are you Jang Bo?”

“No. I said my name ends in Bo.”

“What’s the other character?”

“Curious, are you?”

“Yeah!”

“Fine. Use polite speech properly for the next month, and I’ll think about telling you.”

“Wow, that’s mean.”

Old Man Jang let out a quiet laugh as the boy puffed out his cheeks.

“Hng. Can’t you just tell me? I need to know so I can eat something tasty.”

“…?”

“Whew. I guess it can’t be helped.”

What was that supposed to mean?

As Old Man Jang wondered, the boy heaved a sigh like an old man and sprang to his feet.

“Where are you going?”

“I’ll come back later!”

“Don’t bother. The sun’s already down, you brat. Go home and sleep!”

“I don’t want to!”

For someone with such short legs, the boy had boundless energy. He quickly disappeared in the opposite direction from his house.

“That boy never listens.”

Muttering under his breath, Old Man Jang hauled his stiff body upright.

Until about ten years ago, he had still been able to manage well enough. But once he began losing muscle, his joints started aching all over.

“Good grief. I’d better warm up the room.”

He fed firewood into the firebox and lit the brazier.

After puttering around for a while, he stepped outside to use the privy before bed.

That was when—

“Grandpa!”

The boy’s innocent cry rang out.

But Old Man Jang did not hear it.

His seasoned gaze was fixed on the three large men standing behind the child.

Martial artists?

The sun had already set, leaving their faces hidden in darkness, but he could clearly make out the sword sheaths protruding from their waists.

He had made countless such objects himself.

Without taking his eyes off the men, Old Man Jang beckoned to the boy.

“Hanga, come here.”

“Yeah!”

Now that he looked, the boy was clutching a large bundle to his chest. It radiated warmth and gave off an appetizing smell.

Having roughly grasped the situation, Old Man Jang glared at the figures in the darkness.

“Who are you?”

A spark snapped in the darkness, then flared to life. The fire starter in someone’s hand illuminated the three men’s faces.

They were all young men around twenty. One stepped forward.

“My goodness. Good evening.”

He had a handsome face and a sly smile.

Old Man Jang studied the vaguely familiar face before speaking.

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

He had seen that face from a distance about half a month ago.

The young man, Jin Taekyung, broke into a wide grin.

“Oh, you know the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. That’s me. Hahaha.”

“An old man named Jang?”

“Yes. I was told he definitely lived in this village.”

“Well, there are so many of them. There must be twenty old men with the family name Jang.”

“He’s around eighty…”

“They all suffered when they were young, so they’ve all aged about the same. Mr. Jang next door is fifty, but he looks a hundred and fifty.”

“…”

“Anyway, they’re all like that.”

“Um, he lives alone, and his name is…”

“Who bothers remembering everyone’s name? Once they get old, they’re all just Old Man Jang. Plenty of people live alone too. War, drought, epidemics… Whew.”

“…”

Damn it. We had arrived before sunset, only to run into trouble immediately.

I had wondered why such a tiny village had so many old men named Jang. It turned out to be a clan village.[947] Half the people we passed on the road had the family name Jang.

"Do you know where he lives?"

As Hyuk Mujin grew frustrated, I waved the letter containing the information in front of him.

"No. It only says he lives here. I guess they thought we'd find him quickly since it's a small village."

Cheongpung pulled some meat from his bundle and began tearing into it.

"Chomp, chomp, chomp."

"Then how are we supposed to find him? Jang is already a common family name."

"We'll have to find out for ourselves. There are only a few hundred people here, and he's an old man, so we should locate him quickly."

"Chomp, chomp, chomp."

"…"

"…"

That bastard Cheongpung had done nothing but eat this whole time.

Then again, maybe that could work in my favor. I was just about to give up and ask him for a piece of meat when—

"Oh, the grandpa who lives three houses down from us is a Jang too."

The speaker was a little boy whose head barely reached my waist. With his enormous eyes, he was pretty cute.

I ruffled his shaggy hair.

"Really?"

"Yeah. He's Grandpa Jang."

"Really?"

I played along, though I wasn't expecting much. The woman selling vegetables at the roadside stall was a Jang, and so was the butcher over there. In a clan village crawling with Jangs, what were the odds?

The boy sniffed and continued.

"Grandpa is always alone. He doesn't have a family, so I go play with him."

"Oh, you little rascal. That's kind of you—wait. He doesn't have a family?"

"Yeah! I asked Mom, and she said he'd been alone ever since he first came here."

"Since he first came here? He isn't originally from this village?"

The boy nodded vigorously.

"My dad told me Grandpa came from somewhere else. Since he came from outside, he doesn't have any friends or family."

[947] A clan village is a settlement where many households share the same family name and ancestral lineage.

"I see."

Hyuk Mujin and I exchanged glances. This sounded promising, but it was hardly conclusive.

"Little one, do you know his name?"

"Do you know anything else about him?"

"I don't know his name. He's just Grandpa Jang."

It seemed that was all the boy knew. Hyuk Mujin asked with an eerily kind smile,

"Little one, could you tell us where he lives?"

"Waaay over there. At the edge of the village."

As expected of the continent. This damn village was absurdly large for its population.

Hyuk Mujin roughly gauged the distance before turning to me.

"It'll take about fifteen minutes."

Even on horseback, it would take that long. I shook my head.

"What if he isn't the one? Let's search nearby first and work our way over there."

"Yes, that's probably better. Aside from the fact that he came from elsewhere, there's nothing that really marks him as the man we're looking for."

Cheongpung nodded.

"Chomp. Chomp. Chomp."

"…"

"…"

While I wondered whether I should simply hurl away that food bundle, the boy boldly held out both his little hands toward Cheongpung.

"Hmm?"

"Grandpa Jang said there's no such thing as a favor without a price."

The kid already understood how the world worked.

He had given us information, so now he wanted a bite in return. That Grandpa Jang or whatever his name was sure had taught a fine lesson to a child of five or six.

"Wow, my grandfather said something similar. Here."

"Wow! Thank you!"

Look at them, united under the banner of grandfathers.

Cheongpung casually handed him a large leg of meat. He had been periodically warming the food with the Zaha Divine Technique, which was based on Scorching Yang Qi, so the meat was still hot.

He's using the Zaha Divine Technique to heat meat?

The boy happily tore into the meat, then looked at us with naked longing in his eyes.

"By the way, I need to go home anyway. And on the way back, I'm going to visit Grandpa Jang three houses down."

"Oh, really?"

I immediately understood what he meant. When you were desperate, you would borrow even a cat's paw. Why not a child's?

"Then could you ask Grandpa Jang his name? Meet us back here in half a shichen.[948]"

"Hmm. I think I'll be even hungrier by then."

"See those food bundles? I'll give you a whole one."

"Really?"

The boy's eyes lit up, but then he hesitated.

"Why are you looking for Grandpa Jang?"

"It's nothing serious. We just have a favor to ask him."

"You're not bad people, are you?"

Introducing myself as the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi from the Jin Family of Taiyuan would only draw a crowd. I gave him my most innocent smile.

"Of course not."

"Ugh. Why are you smiling like such a bad person?"

"…"

Should I just smack him on the head and send him away?

Hyuk Mujin stepped in on my behalf.

"I'll give you two bundles."

"So you were good people after all. I'll be back!"

The child was already becoming a monster born of capitalism.

Hyuk Mujin shrugged.

"Where should we start looking?"

"Search everything from the nearest entrance onward."

"That'll take half a shichen.[949]"

Hyuk Mujin was wrong. It took us more than half a shichen[950] to search half the village.

Then the boy returned with an extremely valuable clue.

If his name starts with Jang and ends with Bo…

The former Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild, Jang Taebo.

That had to be him.

[948] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[949] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[950] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“Oh, you know the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. That’s me. Hahaha.”

The fact that he knew who I was was a good sign. It felt strange to say this about myself, but wasn’t the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi practically Shanxi Province’s idol?

If this world had internet access, I would already have a fan club.

“I’m sorry to visit so late at night. The thing is, I have a favor to ask…”

“There’s no need.”

“Pardon?”

Jang Taebo was over eighty, but he still had a sturdy build. He fixed me with a cantankerous stare.

“I won’t accept the commission anyway.”

“Still, you should at least hear what it is…”

“No!”

Well, that was decisive.

Chapter 167

"No!"

What a set of lungs.

The shout rang out so loudly that it belied the speaker's eighty years, and Cheongpung gulped down whatever was in his mouth.

"Benefactor, he really doesn't want to do it, does he?"

I heard him, you idiot.

I'd heard he was pretty cantankerous, but I hadn't expected this.

Still, if a few shouts were enough to make me back down, I never would have come this far in the first place. I calmly tried again.

"Elder, please calm down and hear me out—"

"What is there to hear? You want me to make you a weapon, don't you?"

"Uh, well, yes."

"You barge in on an old man who retired ten years ago, in the middle of the night no less, and ask him to make you something meant for killing people?"

Jang Taebo glared and shouted,

"Get out of my sight this instant!"

"Waaah!"

At the sound of yet another shout, the little boy in Jang Taebo's arms burst into tears.

Holding the fire starter, Hyuk Mujin muttered quietly enough that only I could hear him.

"What a temper on that old man…"

I agreed, though it was also true that I'd been in too much of a hurry.

Judging by the way things were going, he wouldn't accept my commission even if I died and came back to life.

This is a problem.

I had to be back by tomorrow for the New Year's Day banquet.

As I hesitated, villagers alarmed by the commotion began poking their heads out of their doors one by one.

"What's all this racket?"

"That was Old Man Jang's voice, wasn't it? I heard Hanga crying next door, too."

"Elder, is something wrong over there?"

There was nothing to gain from having our identities exposed here. No—in fact, they were the ones who stood to lose.

Jang Taebo frowned.

“It’s nothing. Seems some young men got dead drunk and came to the wrong house.”

“Tsk, tsk. Young people these days are all like that. If you need any help…”

“Your concern is enough.”

At his firm reply, the open doors closed one by one, and the murmuring voices abruptly fell silent.

When the surroundings grew quiet, Jang Taebo fixed us with his bulging eyes.

“Go home. And don’t come back.”

His tone was gentler than before, and his voice had dropped, but icicles still seemed to fall from every word.

There was nothing to be done. I turned away and bowed toward Jang Taebo’s back as he soothed the whimpering child.

“I’ll come see you again tomorrow.”

“You’re hard of hearing, aren’t you? Didn’t you hear what I just said?”

“…Then we’ll be going.”

I was about to leave when another thought occurred to me, something that might move him even a little.

“I truly need the help of a Master Artisan. That’s why I came to find you, elder.”

But Jang Taebo answered without even looking back.

“Go west for one shichen[951] and you’ll find a large village with a smithy. The owner there is fairly skilled.”

“Is he skilled enough to forge Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?”

Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron—a mysterious mineral imbued with supernatural properties, the hardest and sharpest material in the world, capable of withstanding even Sword Energy.

It was so valuable and rare that even highly skilled blacksmiths could go their entire lives without ever laying eyes on it.

If anything could pique his interest, it would be Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

But Jang Taebo’s reaction fell far short of my expectations.

“Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron? Then go to the Ironcraft Guild. Leave it with that Guild Leader fellow, and he should do a passable job. He learned a thing or two by watching me work.”

The indifference in his voice told me everything.

To him now, even a legendary metal like Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron was no different from copper.

“It’s late.”

[951] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

It was an unmistakable dismissal. I had no choice but to turn away. Hyuk Mujin and Cheongpung followed me.

“What are you going to do?”

“What do you mean? I’ll keep pestering him until tomorrow.”

“Chomp, chomp, chomp.”

“He’s not just stubborn… By the way, where did you get the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?”

“That’s a long story.”

“Chomp, chomp, chomp.”

“…”

“…”

Cheongpung cautiously studied the looks Hyuk Mujin and I were giving him, then held out a bundle.

“Would either of you like some? There’s still plenty left.”

We shouted in unison.

“We’re not eating it!”

We spent the night at a half-collapsed inn. As the only inn in the small village, it was old and shabby in every possible way, but it did have one advantage.

The innkeeper was a local who had lived in the Jang clan village for forty years.

He had been wary of the three of us, dressed as martial artists, but the moment I pressed a silver nyang[952] into his hand, his grin stretched from ear to ear.

“Old Man Jang?”

“Yes. The man who lives over the hill.”

The innkeeper immediately nodded.

“Ah, of course I know him. He comes to our inn from time to time.”

“Does he?”

“Yes. Sometimes he drinks by himself, and sometimes he joins a gambling game.”

“He likes gambling?”

“Not exactly. I think he only does it to pass the time. Usually, he barely leaves his house once every seven days.”

“He’s a homebody.”

“Pardon?”

“Nothing. I was talking to myself. Is he any good at gambling?”

The innkeeper thought for a moment before answering.

[952] A nyang is a traditional unit of weight and currency; here, it denotes an amount of silver used as payment.

“He’s about average. If anything, he tends to lose a little each time. But considering he keeps coming despite not working for a living, I suppose he must have made a fortune in his youth.”

That made sense. Geeks never spared any expense when it came to their obsessions.

Every martial artist was a weapon geek in one way or another, and Jang Taebo was one of the best custom weapon makers in the world.

He had clearly earned more money than most.

So luring him with money is out?

I’d suspected as much after last night, but the man really was difficult.

A deal only worked when you could satisfy something the other party wanted, and Jang Taebo seemed quite content with his current life.

“Is there anything else? Does he ever make things, for example?”

“Make things?”

“You know, like kitchen knives or pickaxes.”

A repetitive life eventually became a habit. That had to be especially true of someone like Jang Taebo, who had spent his entire life working with fire and iron.

If I were in his position, I’d be too restless to sit still.

But the innkeeper gave me a strange look.

“Old Man Jang? He hates moving so much that he pays the Escort Bureau extra to deliver his winter firewood. I’ve never heard of him making anything.”

“…”

Escort Bureau rocket delivery, huh?

A homebody with a severe case of laziness. There wasn’t a single opening to exploit.

Hyuk Mujin and Cheongpung, who had been listening while they ate breakfast, suddenly joined in.

“He’s completely impenetrable.”

“Chomp, chomp. Wow, I’ve never seen anyone like that before.”

“…I’ve never seen anyone like you before, either.”

One of the inn’s flaws was that the food was absolutely terrible.

The state of the owner’s hands alone raised serious questions about the place’s hygiene, but Cheongpung swept up the remaining food as though none of that mattered.

“Is it good?”

“Yes! When I lived with Grandpa, all I ate was grass and fasting pills every day.”

“Ah, fasting pills.”

That, I could understand. I'd rather make pancakes out of Jinho hyung's[953] vomit than eat those.

"…"

"Captain, why do you look like that?"

"Munch, munch. Benefactor, is something wrong?"

"…No. My stomach just feels a little queasy."

On second thought, even that was going too far.

I rose from my seat after watching Cheongpung clean out the last plate.

"All right, let's go."

"Already? It's only between seven and nine in the morning."

"Can I have just one more dumpling?"

The innkeeper quickly cut in.

"Old Man Jang is getting on in years, so he doesn't sleep late in the morning. And I'll pack the dumplings for you right now."

"There. Happy?"

I handed the innkeeper another silver nyang[954]. He stood in front of the inn and waved until we disappeared from view.

"Elder, did you sleep well?"

Jang Taebo was standing in the courtyard. When he saw us, he frowned. More precisely, he frowned when he saw me.

"I believe I told you not to come back."

"Could I really just leave after coming all this way?"

I gave him an easygoing smile.

Back when I was a lowest-level Hunter, people had hurled obscenities right to my face. This was nothing.

"It felt wrong to come empty-handed, so I brought you a small gift."

"Hmm?"

"The innkeeper was quite talkative. Apparently, an acquaintance of his dug up a thirty-year-old He Shou Wu[955] not long ago."

He Shou Wu was still used as a medicinal herb in the modern world.

Century-old and millennium-old He Shou Wu appeared all the time in martial arts novels, but here, even finding a thirty-year-old specimen was said to be as difficult as plucking a star from the sky.

---

[953] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[954] A nyang is a traditional unit of weight and currency; here, it denotes an amount of silver used as payment.

[955] He Shou Wu is a traditional medicinal herb made from the tuberous root of *Polygonum multiflorum*.

In other words, it was hard to find in this area even if you had money.

“A thirty-year-old He Shou Wu… So?”

“I was worried you might be feeling weak lately. It made me think of you, so I brought it along.”

Jinho hyung[956] was always saying that the body started breaking down once a person passed thirty.

Your eyes got dry, your stomach started burning, and the day after you lent someone a USB, you could barely stand on your own legs.

If that was what happened to Jinho hyung[957] in the prime of his life, how much worse must it be for the elderly? A thirty-year-old He Shou Wu was perfect for looking after one’s health.

“Hmm. Why don’t you eat it?”

“Oh, goodness, me? No, no. I brought it for you, elder.”

The bait had caught his interest.

Feeling a tug on the line, I held out the He Shou Wu.

Properly consumed, it could provide about a year’s worth of internal energy, but I didn’t begrudge it in the slightest.

“Please, eat it. They say it’s best to chew it raw, roots and all.”

“Hmm. Should I?”

Yes, hurry up and eat it, then spit out a Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron spear.

At my bright smile, Jang Taebo popped the He Shou Wu into his mouth and began chewing noisily. The atmosphere was completely different from last night.

Oh, this is looking good.

If I coaxed him gently while the atmosphere was this pleasant, then submitted my commission…!

But the next moment, I heard the sound of my hopeful future being abruptly cut off.

“Ptooey!”

“…?”

“…?”

“…?”

Hyuk Mujin, Cheongpung, and I stared at the half-chewed He Shou Wu lying on the ground.

He spat it out? A thirty-year-old He Shou Wu? Why?

When we stared at him in confusion, Jang Taebo asked as though nothing had happened.

“Why are you looking at me like that? Is something wrong?”

---

[956] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[957] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

"...Why did you spit it out?"

"It's bitter."

"Pardon?"

"I said it's bitter."

His unabashed answer left me speechless.

What kind of bullshit was that?

"Of course it's bitter. It's good for you."

"Tsk, tsk. You've never eaten He Shou Wu before, have you?"

"...No."

I had eaten Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng once, but I hadn't been in my own body at the time, so I couldn't say.

When I found myself agreeing, Jang Taebo rummaged through his robes and tossed something at me.

"What is this?"

I caught it and found myself holding a wooden box about the size of a pencil case. Jang Taebo gave me a scornful smile.

"Open it."

For a man who only gambled occasionally, he sounded exactly like a cardsharp.

I opened the wooden box with an inexplicable sense of tension.

"A fake! ...Wait, no, it's He Shou Wu?"

He Shou Wu?

And not just any He Shou Wu.

Its body and roots were thicker than those of the He Shou Wu I'd given Jang Taebo moments ago.

A fragrant scent struck my nose.

Item check.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Fifty-Year-Old He Shou Wu
Type: Spirit Herb
Grade: First Rate
Restriction: None
Description: He Shou Wu that grew in nature for fifty years and has finally begun to hold spiritual energy. If absorbed by a martial artist who has learned a cultivation technique, it can provide up to about two years of internal energy.

"…"

Even a thirty-year-old specimen was supposed to be difficult to obtain. Where on earth had he gotten one that was fifty years old?

I was too dumbfounded to speak. Jang Taebo gave me a triumphant smile.

"It comes through the Nine-Room Escort Bureau once every four months. The head of the bureau owes me a favor. He knows how to keep his mouth shut, too."

"…I see."

So it was a regular delivery from the Nine-Room Escort Bureau. No wonder the old man looked healthier than most young men.

"Enough with these transparent tricks. I'm a man who no longer needs anything."

"You certainly seem that way."

He had money saved up and had achieved professional success.

He even had a full head of hair.

The only thing he lacked was a family—but if I offered to introduce him to a pretty old lady, he'd probably try to kill me.

"What would it take for you to accept my commission?"

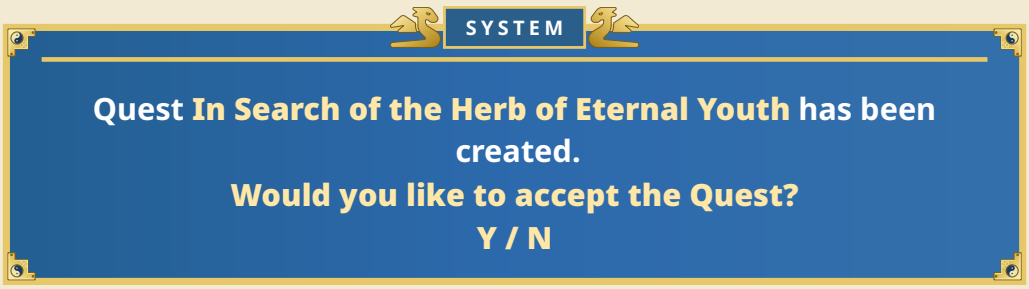
Jang Taebo dug his pinky into his ear.

"Bring me the Herb of Eternal Youth, and I'll think about it."

"Pardon?"

"You didn't hear me? The Herb of Eternal Youth. The spirit herb said to grant eternal youth and immortality."

Ding.



This time, I shouted,

"No!"

Chapter 168

Quest

SYSTEM

In Search of the Herb of Eternal Youth
This spirit herb exists only in legend.
Rulers who dreamed of immortality and eternal youth poured vast amounts of wealth and manpower into searching for the Herb of Eternal Youth, but no one has ever found it.
However, if you have about a thousand years left to live, it might not be a bad idea to give it a try.
Grade: ???
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Acquire the Herb of Eternal Youth (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

"No!"

Beep.

SYSTEM

You rejected the Quest.

Just look at this damn quest. Even its Grade was nothing but question marks.

What? "If you have about a thousand years left to live, it might not be a bad idea to give it a try"?

What kind of bullshit was that?

At my incredulous stare, Jang Taebo stroked his beard.

"What? Can't you do it?"

"...How exactly am I supposed to do that?"

"Then forget it. Give me back the He Shou Wu.[958]"

Jang Taebo snatched the He Shou Wu[959] from my hand and began chewing it with a crisp crunch.

"Oh, it's sweet. Just what you'd expect from a fifty-year-old specimen."

"..."

"Hm? Are you all still standing there? Did you need something?"

[958] He Shou Wu is a plant used in traditional Chinese medicine.
[959] He Shou Wu is a plant used in traditional Chinese medicine.

“No, elder.”

“Why?”

“Does asking someone to bring you the Herb of Eternal Youth sound remotely reasonable?”

“It’s been a long time since I met someone who cared about common sense in the Murim. There’s Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, so why wouldn’t there be an Herb of Eternal Youth?”

“…”

That sounded surprisingly plausible.

I almost let myself be persuaded, but quickly came to my senses. Somehow, I had to convince this old man who seemed impervious even to a needle.

“If there’s anything else you need, I’ll get it for you. Anything you want. Just not something like the Herb of Eternal Youth.”

“Really?”

“Of course. If necessary, I’ll mobilize the full strength of my family.”

“Hm. I’ve heard plenty about how formidable the Jin Family of Taiyuan has become these days.”

Jang Taebo nodded and opened his mouth.

“Then I’m thirsty. Bring me a bottle of gongcheong seokyu.[960]”

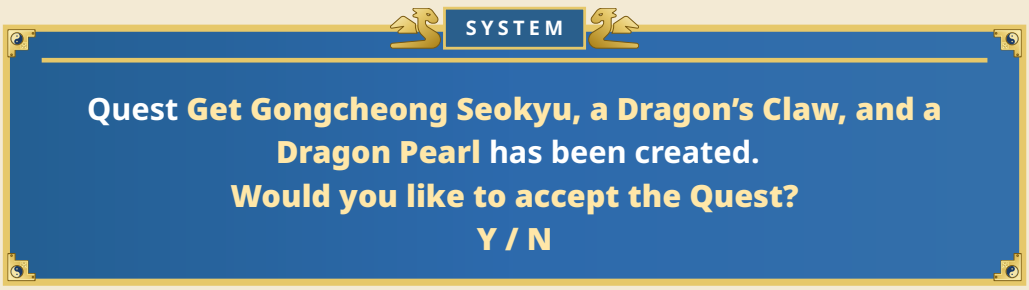
“Pardon?”

Gongcheong seokyu[961]? The stuff said to grant a jiazi[962] of internal energy with a single drop?

I barely stopped myself from letting loose a stream of profanity. Jang Taebo continued with a sly grin.

“You said you wanted to make a weapon out of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, didn’t you? Then you’ll need a fine scabbard, too. I hear there’s a dragon at the end of the world. Pull out one of its claws and bring it back. And while you’re at it, bring me a dragon pearl.”

Ding.



[960] Gongcheong seokyu is a rare martial-arts elixir. Its Korean name also carries a petroleum-related pun.

[961] Gongcheong seokyu is a rare martial-arts elixir. Its Korean name also carries a petroleum-related pun.

[962] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

…As if.

Feeling my insides boil, I closed the Quest window. Hyuk Mujin covered his mouth and whispered,

“I think the old man’s senile.”

“I can hear you. You wet-behind-the-ears brat certainly have a lot to say.”

Just as Jang Taebo began waving a fist the size of a pot lid, Cheongpung thrust his hand into the air and shouted,

“I’ll go find them! Let me do it!”

“What?”

“The Herb of Eternal Youth! Gongcheong seokyu[963]! A dragon!”

At last, the neighborhood’s resident lunatic had stepped forward.

His eyes sparkled like morning stars, and his every gesture burned with enthusiasm. Faced with Cheongpung’s intensity, Jang Taebo flinched and took a step back.

“Who are you?”

Cheongpung answered energetically,

“I’m my grandpa’s grandson!”

“Who’s your grandfather?”

“My grandpa!”

“…What a lunatic.”

Welcome. First time dealing with Cheongpung?

As Jang Taebo shook his head from side to side, I casually added,

“Do you happen to know Great Hero Mae Jonghak?”

“Though I’m not a martial artist, I’ve spent my entire life with one foot in the Murim. Do you think I wouldn’t know the Sword Saint, whom even butchers have heard of?”

“That friend is the disciple personally raised and taught by the Sword Saint.”

“What? Is that true?”

“Why would I lie? Especially while staking the name of someone as distinguished as the Sword Saint?”

“Hah. So he’s the Sword Saint’s successor…”

Had that worked? No matter where you went in the world, connections were king: school ties, hometown ties, and blood ties.

In the Murim, the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak’s very existence inspired respect and awe.

Jang Taebo stared at Cheongpung in evident surprise, then opened his mouth.

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[963] Gongcheong seokyu is a rare martial-arts elixir. Its Korean name also carries a petroleum-related pun.

“So what do you want me to do about it?”

“Ah…”

“I have nothing to do with Huashan. Well, I did make a sword at the request of the current Sect Leader of Huashan, Heavenly Sword True Person,[964] about thirty years ago. But that’s all.”

His firm voice continued.

“I’m eighty years old. I’m still in good health, and I’ve accumulated plenty of wealth. As a man who has worked iron all his life, I can proudly say that I rank among the top three in the world.”

“That’s why I’m asking you.”

“That’s why I’m refusing you. I’ve finished all the work I care to do. I’ve made swords until I’m sick of them.”

“I use a spear.”

“Oh, did you?”

“Yes.”

“A spear would take even more work. I’d rather make a sword.”

“Elder!”

I grabbed Jang Taebo’s hand and gave him an earnest look.

“Couldn’t you think of it as something to pass the time and help me just this once?”

“When did I say I wouldn’t?”

“You just said you wouldn’t.”

Jang Taebo harshly shook off my hand.

“I said I’d help you. If you bring me the Herb of Eternal Youth.”

“Oh, please.”

“Bring me the gongcheong seokyu[965] and dragon pearl while you’re at it. I hear that when fighting a dragon, you should avoid its tail, circle around behind it, and choke its neck. I’m telling you so you don’t get hurt.”

“…A dragon isn’t a person. How am I supposed to kill it by choking it?”

“Then burst its balls.”

“What if it’s female?”

“See you in the next life.”

I had finally met a formidable opponent.

His way of screwing with people had been honed over decades. My fists trembled, and the back of my head throbbed.

“Are you really going to be like this?”

---

[964] “Heavenly Sword True Person” is a Taoist-style title; “True Person” is an honorific for someone regarded as spiritually accomplished.

[965] Gongcheong seokyu is a rare martial-arts elixir. Its Korean name also carries a petroleum-related pun.

“That is precisely how I’m going to be.”

“I didn’t want to go this far…”

“Go on. Spit it out.”

“Should I spread the word that the former Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild lives here?”

I was only saying it. Obviously, I had no intention of actually doing it.

But Jang Taebo merely grinned at my threat to make his life difficult.

“Then I suppose I have no choice. I’ll have to return to the Ironcraft Guild before all sorts of gnats start swarming around.”

“Huh?”

This wasn’t how it was supposed to go. As I was thinking that, Jang Taebo asked,

“If I return to the Ironcraft Guild, what do you think I’ll do?”

“…How would I know?”

“I’ll devote the rest of my life to making ten weapons. Then I’ll distribute those weapons, each made with all my heart and soul, to the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang,[966] while having in-depth conversations with them about the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Your name will come up quite a lot, especially.”

“W-What are you planning to tell them?”

“I’ll leave that to your imagination. Oh, and you do know that martial artists will stake their lives on their weapons regardless of how advanced their martial arts are, don’t you? I’m sure they’ll be happy to grant a small request of mine.”

“…”

It might be a small request to the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang,[967] but it would be anything but small to me or the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

If he bad-mouthed us with even a few words in front of them, a hit to our reputation would be the least of it. We might even face real pressure from them.

“Well, I suppose I should start preparing to leave. Let’s see, what should I pack…?”

As he turned to go into his room and pack, I grabbed his wrist. Jang Taebo asked innocently,

“What is it?”

I lowered my head helplessly.

“Please stop. I admit defeat.”

“Is that all?”

“I’m sorry for acting cocky.”

“And?”

“I won’t tell anyone that you’re living here.”

---

[966] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a major grouping of martial-arts organizations in the Murim.

[967] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a major grouping of martial-arts organizations in the Murim.

“Given that you came looking for me like this, it can’t be something only you know, can it?”

“I’ll explain everything properly to my eldest brother, too.”

“You’re sure?”

“Of course.”

“Hm. You’re not completely ill-mannered, then.”

Having gotten every answer he wanted, Jang Taebo smiled with satisfaction.

I had defeated enemies stronger than me time and again, but I couldn’t break the will of an old man enjoying a quiet retirement.

So where am I supposed to have the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron forged?

I’d finally thought I was about to have my first cherished weapon…

I was staring dejectedly at the half-chewed, discarded He Shou Wu[968] when Jang Taebo spoke.

“You said you were making a spear?”

“Pardon?”

“Are you deaf? Why do you keep asking me to repeat myself?”

I hurriedly raised my head and saw Jang Taebo’s gruff face. He continued,

“Well, if you ask me to make it myself, I’ll obviously refuse. But I can at least give you an introduction.”

“You mean the Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild, your disciple…”

“Do you think the Guild Leader has that much time on his hands? He’s busy, too. Even someone like you would have to wait several years at the very least.”

“Several years?”

“What, did you think a weapon could be completed overnight? He’s not as good as me, but he’s skilled enough that his orders are bound to be backed up. Even picking and choosing which ones to accept, it still takes that long.”

Even so, several years?

The prospect of such an unexpectedly long project left me short of breath.

“T-Then what do I do?”

“What do you mean, what do you do? I’ll write you a letter of introduction. Take it with you. You’ll be going there with a recommendation from his master, so he’ll probably finish it a little sooner. That fellow makes one hell of a spear.”

“Ooh. Ooooh.”

“The village was in an uproar because of those mounted bandits, and I heard you were the one who dealt with them. I’ll do this for you as a special favor. Do you have paper, a brush, and ink?”

Hyuk Mujin, suddenly singled out, answered with a bewildered expression,

[968] He Shou Wu is a plant used in traditional Chinese medicine.

"No."

"Right. One look at you, and I can tell you don't carry such things. Then what about you…?"

"Chomp, chomp, chomp."

He's eating those now?

Jang Taebo sighed at the sight of Cheongpung stuffing the dumplings we had bought at the inn into his mouth until his cheeks looked ready to burst.

"…Are the dumplings good?"

"Chomp, chomp. Yes."

"Mae Jonghak took in a strange one in his later years. Fine, wait here a moment."

"Old people should just die. Young people these days have no manners."

Muttering loudly enough for us to hear, Jang Taebo went inside and returned with paper, a brush, and ink.

"First, the weapon is a spear… Do you have a particular shape or weight in mind?"

"Ah, yes."

"Tell me."

I described in detail the weight and shape that had become thoroughly familiar to me over seven years of wielding a spear.

Each time, Jang Taebo either nodded silently or added advice on how to make a spear better suited to me.

He really is an expert.

Sixty years in the trade had not gone to waste.

He gave my body a quick once-over, then rattled off one correction after another. He gauged the size of my hands and the length of my arms and legs with uncanny accuracy, then adjusted the thickness and shape of the spear shaft little by little.

"All right, this is the last thing. Where are you planning to put the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron? In the spearhead, presumably?"

"…?"

"Why are you making that face? You said you had Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. You're not planning to leave it out, are you?"

"No, I'm going to use it…"

"Do you not have much? By my estimate, ten nyang should be enough to produce something worthy of being called a renowned spear. You could pass it down as a family heirloom without shame."

How much was ten nyang? I still wasn't used to the unit of weight, so I had no idea.

As I hesitated, Jang Taebo barked,

"Ah! How much of it are you going to put in?"

"That's… Just a moment."

Seeing was believing. It would be faster to show him directly.

Pretending to rummage through my travel bag, I took the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron from my Inventory and casually held it out.

“It’s about this much.”

“…”

“Elder?”

Jang Taebo didn’t answer. He stared intently at the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, which was larger than an adult’s head, for a long time before asking in an intensely hoarse voice,

“This… This is all Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?”

“Yes. This isn’t your first time seeing it, is it?”

“I-I can’t believe this.”

His wrinkled hands trembled faintly. Jang Taebo stroked the cold, blue-tinged Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron as though he had been reunited with a child after sixty years. A sharp light flashed in his eyes.

“Entrust it to me.”

The old man who had found everything a nuisance was nowhere to be seen. His voice brimmed with passion and vitality.

“I’ll make you the greatest divine weapon in the world.”

Ding.

Chapter 169

In the dim light before dawn, a group of people made their way through the thick fog.

At their head, two middle-aged men spoke in low voices.

“Are you sure the information is reliable?”

“More than ninety percent.”

“Ninety percent?”

“I can’t be certain until we confirm it ourselves.”

“Then the other ten percent…”

“They may have leaked the information deliberately.”

“Which would make this a trap.”

“That’s why we’re taking every possible precaution, isn’t it?”

The two middle-aged men swallowed hard. So did everyone following them.

Each man gripped his weapon tightly, his eyes brimming with anxiety and tension.

“Damn it. We really stepped in shit.”

“Same here. I had a bad feeling from the moment they put me in charge of the Datong Branch.”

The two middle-aged men exchanged sympathetic looks. They were the Branch Leaders of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Lower District Sect’s respective Datong Branches, both established barely a month ago.

“I was bragging to my wife about my promotion just the other day. At this rate, I’m going to make her a widow.”

“Stop whining. I told you, we’re more than ninety percent certain.”

“And if we land in the other ten percent?”

“We die surrounded by more than four hundred mounted bandits.”

“…”

“Look at your face. Enough with the ill-omened talk. Watch where you’re going—we should be there soon.”

After the Lower District Sect Branch Leader finished speaking, silence descended.

They continued forward, slow but steady, muffling even their footsteps. The dense fog blanketing the area concealed both their figures and the sounds they made.

How long had they been walking?

By the time everyone was drenched in sweat and moisture—

“Stop!”

The low, restrained shout came from the Datong Branch Leader of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Gripping the hilt of his sword hard enough to crush it, he asked the Lower District Sect Branch Leader,

"Did you hear that?"

"What…? Ah!"

The Lower District Sect Branch Leader's face stiffened.

A sound from beyond the fog had reached his ears.

That's…

Horses snorting. And not just one or two.

The two men raised clenched fists. At once, dozens of sword blades smeared black with ash emerged from their sheaths.

Beyond the dense fog, which limited their vision to less than a zhang,[969] it felt as though hundreds of mounted bandits armed with bows and lances might come charging out at any moment.

Gulp.

Just as someone's throat bobbed loudly, a sudden gust swept across the grassland and brushed away the fog.

The sight it revealed made everyone's eyes fly open.

"Gasp!"

"W-What in the world…?"

Beneath the grassland's blue sky lay a field of red. The earth had been scorched black, and the stench of blood and death hung heavy in the air.

The Lower District Sect Branch Leader groaned involuntarily.

"So the information was true."

Dozens of bewildered gazes swept the area. Hundreds of men and horses lay sprawled across the ground, every trace of life already gone.

Severed limbs lay scattered like weeds, and eyes frozen wide with terror and shock stared blankly into space.

The few horses that remained alive let out hungry snorts as they trampled a flag covered in hastily scrawled red characters.

HEAVENLY WIND

There was no mistake. It was the flag of the Heavenly Wind Band.

The annihilation of the Heavenly Wind Band, which had once made a name for itself throughout the northern Gaoyuan through its brutality. The ninety-percent guess had finally become a hundred-percent certainty.

For nearly half a month, the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Lower District Sect had been closely monitoring the Heavenly Wind Band's movements. They should have felt the relief of having a rotten tooth pulled, yet the longer the two Branch Leaders surveyed the scene, the darker their faces became.

"T-This…"

[969] A zhang is a traditional Chinese length unit of approximately 3.33 meters (10.9 ft).

“That’s right. One person did all this.”

The scattered corpses told the story themselves.

A single person had killed them all.

“What a terrifying master. I can’t even begin to fathom his strength.”

The Jin Family Branch Leader, the strongest martial artist among them, continued in a trembling voice.

“Every one of them was killed in a single strike. Judging by their burned-out organs, the killer must have cultivated Scorching Yang Qi to its utmost limit.”

“W-What about his martial arts? Can you tell what he used?”

“Not at all. He didn’t use any distinctive martial art. This was… nothing but overwhelming power crushing everything in its path.”

One person had slaughtered four hundred mounted bandits as easily as crushing ants.

The bodies strewn in every direction showed that they had tried to flee. Their horribly contorted faces showed the terror they had felt.

Not a single person had escaped the hands of this unidentified master and his fearsome martial arts.

“C-Could something like this really be possible?”

“It must be. We’re seeing it with our own eyes.”

He was right. The scene before them was both evidence and witness.

The two men fell silent, unable to find anything more to say.

“Over here! There’s a survivor!”

A survivor?

Their eyes snapped open at the sudden shout. The two Branch Leaders immediately displayed their movement techniques and ran like the wind. As they arrived, they muttered like men groaning in disbelief.

“A survivor?”

“He’s still breathing. Not for much longer, though.”

As the man had said, the sole survivor was already little better than a corpse.

His left arm had been ripped off as though devoured by a beast, and a sickening smell of charred flesh rose from the gaping hole in his side.

The Lower District Sect Branch Leader stared intently at the man’s relatively intact face.

“This is the Heavenly Wind Band Leader.”

“…Are you sure?”

“Certain.”

The Heavenly Wind Band Leader had begun making a name for himself ten years ago, and his face was widely known.

Though only recently appointed head of the Lower District Sect's Datong Branch, the Branch Leader had memorized the features of every major figure in the region.

Lately, he had seen the Heavenly Wind Band Leader's face more often than those of his own children.

"He was one of the five strongest men in the Gaoyuan—no, one of the top three… To think he would end up like this."

The chieftains of the mounted-bandit forces ruling the Gaoyuan were all accomplished martial artists, but the Heavenly Wind Band Leader had stood out even among them.

He was dull-witted, but his innate talent for combat alone had made him one of the pillars of the Gaoyuan—a Peak master.

Now, however, he was nothing more than a defeated man on the verge of death.

"I suppose being a Peak master earned him two attacks. One tore off his arm, and the other put a fist through his side."

A Peak master defeated in only two exchanges?

It was so absurd that he could no longer even feel shocked.

Everyone stood speechless when—

"Khrrk. Khrrrk."

A wet rattle came from the Heavenly Wind Band Leader's throat as his body twitched.

He laboriously opened his eyes, and a hoarse voice leaked between his lips.

"Save… save me."

"You're the Heavenly Wind Band Leader. Is that right?"

"Y-Yes. That's me."

The Jin Family Branch Leader sent internal energy toward his wrist. The man's eyes became a little clearer. Just a little.

"Don't worry. You can survive."

It was a lie.

They would gladly have saved him if they could, but it was already too late. There was a mountain of questions they needed answered before he breathed his last.

"Who did this?"

Before the words had fully left his mouth, the Heavenly Wind Band Leader jerked like a bird struck by an arrow. His remaining hand shot up and seized the Branch Leader's collar.

His grip held a strength impossible for a dying man. The stench of death poured from his open mouth.

"An old man. It was an old man. He's a demon who rose from a pit of fire."

"Let go!"

“They’re all dead. I’m dead too. I’m already dead. The demon killed me.”

“Y-You!”

The horrified Branch Leader hurriedly tried to pull away, but the strength slowly drained from the Heavenly Wind Band Leader’s grip.

The lifeless body slowly tipped over and collapsed. His wide-open eyes glared at the blue sky.

“Hah… Hah… Is he dead?”

The Lower District Sect Branch Leader nodded and sighed.

“He had completely lost his mind.”

“No wonder. It’s a miracle he was alive at all. He survived in that condition for nearly two days.”

“At least we learned something.”

“What do we know besides the fact that he was old?”

“He was an old master in the Supreme Peak realm who primarily used Scorching Yang Qi. Judging by the fact that he didn’t leave a single person alive, he’s merciless as well. If he came this way past Datong, he’d attract attention in no time.”

After a moment’s hesitation, the Lower District Sect Branch Leader added,

“…One way or another.”

Whether he was merely an old master who showed no mercy or a great fiend beyond anything they could imagine, they had no way of knowing.

There was only one thing they could do to prepare for the worst.

“We need to send word to our family.”

“I’ll do the same.”

The two men exchanged dark looks, each thinking much the same thing.

Who—or what—was the old man the Heavenly Wind Band Leader spoke of? And…

Where is he now?

The woodcutter met the old man halfway up an unnamed mountain.

The moment he saw the old man strolling leisurely along the rugged mountain path, only one thought crossed his mind.

Is he a mountain spirit?

In all his life, he had never seen anyone so old. Looking at the woodcutter awkwardly prostrating himself, the old man asked,

“What is it?”

“My name is Jang-pal.”

“…So?”

“I’ve come to pay my respects, Mountain Spirit.”

After a brief silence, the old man spoke.

“What kind of lunacy is this…? Are you trying to make a perfectly healthy living man ascend to immortality?”

“Y-You’re not a mountain spirit?”

Jang-pal the woodcutter looked the old man up and down.

Now that he thought about it, more than a few things seemed strange. An immortal should radiate a sacred aura at first glance and speak with dignified elegance…

“Have you ever seen an immortal dressed like this? My robes gape so badly that the cold wind blows straight through them.”

That eccentric way of speaking, those loose clothes torn in places…

The only thing about him that resembled an immortal was his extraordinary age.

“I’m sorry. I’m completely uneducated.”

Jang-pal gave an embarrassed smile, and the old man waved him away.

“If you understand, then be on your way.”

“Yes.”

Jang-pal bowed politely and continued walking.

“…”

“…”

“…You there.”

“Yes?”

The old man scowled.

“Why do you keep following me?”

“Oh, this is the road to my village.”

“What’s down this road?”

“Jang Family Village. It’s a small place. I live there myself.”

“Jang Family Village? From the name, I take it everyone there belongs to the same clan.”

“That’s right.”

The old man clicked his tongue.

“Why are there so many clan villages around here? Half a shichen[970] ago, I passed one called Hong Family Village or something.”

“Hong Family Village?”

“Why? You know it?”

“Yes. Of course I do. But…”

Jang-pal tilted his head.

[970] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

"Hong Family Village should be at least three hundred li[971] from here. Are you perhaps confusing it with somewhere else?"

"Do I look like an idiot who can't remember what happened half a shichen[972] ago?"

Three hundred li[973] was far enough that even Jang-pal, who had sturdy legs, would need two full days to cover it.

But three hundred li[974] in half a shichen[975]?

Jang-pal, a simple country bumpkin, clicked his tongue inwardly in pity.

The poor old man's senile.

His appearance certainly fit. His body was painfully thin, and his hair hung wild and unkempt.

What had brought an old man like him to a mountain climbed only by woodcutters like Jang-pal?

Ah, could it be…?

He suddenly recalled stories of unfilial sons abandoning their elderly parents in the mountains to leave themselves one less mouth to feed. Perhaps this old man had suffered the same fate.

Jang-pal gazed at him with guileless sympathy, then took something from inside his clothes and held it out respectfully.

"Elder, please have this."

"Hmm? What is it?"

Jang-pal scratched the back of his head.

"I brought it along just in case… but I'm full."

It was a rice ball his wife had prepared early that morning. He was hungry after working so hard, but surely the old man before him must be even hungrier.

"It isn't much, but please eat it."

"It certainly doesn't look like much."

"…"

"I'm joking."

The old man glanced between Jang-pal and the crude rice ball.

"My stomach happened to be empty. This will do nicely."

He devoured the palm-sized rice ball in the blink of an eye. Jang-pal then offered him the wooden carrying frame on his back.

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[971] In this Chinese setting, one li is approximately 500 meters (0.311 mi). Three hundred li is about 150 kilometers (93 mi).

[972] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[973] In this Chinese setting, one li is approximately 500 meters (0.311 mi). Three hundred li is about 150 kilometers (93 mi).

[974] In this Chinese setting, one li is approximately 500 meters (0.311 mi). Three hundred li is about 150 kilometers (93 mi).

[975] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“Please climb on. If you sit atop the bundle of firewood, the ride should be bearable.”

“Hmm? You want me to ride on that?”

“Yes. The mountain path is rough, and you’re heading down anyway, aren’t you?”

“I am, but…”

Jang-pal smiled guilelessly.

“You remind me of my father, who passed away long ago.”

A complicated expression crossed the old man’s face. He clicked his tongue, then climbed onto the carrying frame.

He was so light that Jang-pal could lift him with one hand.

“Are you comfortable?”

“These sticks are poking my backside to death.”

“Should I walk a little more slowly?”

“Slowly? You should be running as if you’re flying. Oh, and about that late father of yours…”

“Yes?”

“What sort of man was he? If I reminded you of him, he must have been exceptionally handsome and strapping.”

“…”

Jang-pal suddenly became much less talkative.

Ahead of him, Jang Family Village began to come into view.

Chapter 170

Old and small.

That was the old man's first impression of Jang Family Village.

Seated atop the gently swaying wooden carrying frame, he gazed at the sparse scattering of houses and added in a voice too quiet for anyone to hear,

"…And peaceful."

It seemed the years had passed after all. Even an insignificant view like this made his body relax and a corner of his heart itch.

Just like that day, more than twenty years ago.

It was the same when I took that child in.

The image of a child he had met long ago suddenly flashed before his eyes.

Normally, he would have tossed the child a few iron coins or simply ignored them and walked on. But that day had been different.

Perhaps it was because he had only just realized that he was suffering from the infirmities of old age.

He had stared at the owner of that desperately outstretched hand and, before he knew it, spoken a single sentence.

"Will you come with me?"

"Elder, we're here."

The woodcutter's voice brought the old man back to his senses.

They had stopped in front of a small house. Something tiny burst out from behind a loosely woven fence made of bundles of branches.

"Dad!"

"Oh, my daughter!"

The little girl, no more than six or seven years old, came pattering over and flung herself against her father's leg.

The old man hopped lightly down from the carrying frame and watched them.

"Is she your child?"

"Ah, yes. She is. Hanga, say hello. This gentleman is…"

Come to think of it, Jang-pal did not even know the old man's name.

As he trailed off, the old man waved a hand.

"No need to exchange names. It's nothing."

Just then, Hanga, who had been gazing up at the old man with sparkling eyes, toddled over and slapped his bony thigh.

"Grandpa!"

"Hm?"

"What's your name, Grandpa?"

"I don't know. I've forgotten it too."

The old man had only said it to spare himself the bother, but Jang-pal took it differently.

He's not sound of mind enough to remember even his own name.

As a simple mountain villager, Jang-pal found the old man terribly pitiable.

He could not leave someone who had apparently been abandoned by his children to wander around in clothes scarcely better than rags.

"Elder, why don't you at least stay for a meal? We'll have something ready in no time."

"No need. What you gave me earlier was enough."

"Even so…"

"There's someone I must find. I've already been delayed for quite some time, so I ask for your understanding."

After speaking, the old man paused.

Understanding?

The word that had slipped from his mouth felt foreign.

He had lived his entire life without restraint. Everyone had feared and revered him. Even the most renowned masters of Murim had tucked their tails between their legs in his presence.

And yet such words came easily before this country bumpkin he had known for less than half a shichen.[976]

I'm old. I really have grown old.

As the old man stood there in bewilderment, someone tugged at his sleeve.

He looked down and saw plump, baby-soft cheeks twitching.

"Who are you looking for? Hanga is good at finding people."

"…Is that so?"

"Uh-huh! Yesterday, I found Grandpa Jang from three houses over."

"Well done."

"When I found him, he gave me something tasty. I ate until my belly almost burst."

After that baffling remark, she planted a hand on her waist. Her expression was almost solemn.

"And people need to eat so they'll have strength. At your age, Grandpa, you can even chew up iron."

"H-Hanga!"

"Ha ha ha!"

The old man laughed heartily for the first time in a long while. When was the last time he had laughed like this? It must have been more than ten years ago.

[976] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Once his laughter subsided, he patted Hanga's round head.

"Yes, you're right. This old man can chew up iron."

"Uh-huh. I'm always right."

Beaming with pride, Hanga caught hold of his sleeve and led him into the house. The old man let himself be dragged along.

Even the strongest man under heaven could not have made him budge, but today was an exception. More importantly…

This isn't half bad.

He rather liked the situation. For once, he almost felt like an ordinary old man.

When they entered the room, Jang-pal's wife soon brought out a meal.

"I'm afraid the side dishes aren't much."

As she had said, the food was simple: a few kinds of namul[977] and mixed-grain rice. Even the meat soup they had served for his sake was pale and bland.

But everything had been prepared with care. They were clearly not well-off, yet they treated the shabby old man seated at their table as a guest rather than an unwelcome intruder.

Well, now.

The old man finished the meal with a strange feeling in his heart. Hanga asked him with sparkling eyes,

"Grandpa, was it good?"

"Yes. It was the best meal I've had in quite some time."

"Right? My mom is the best cook in our whole village."

"…Is that so?"

"Uh-huh!"

I wouldn't go that far.

The old man swallowed the words and nodded.

He had not enjoyed the meal for its taste, but for the care with which it had been prepared.

Oblivious, Hanga continued chattering away.

"Grandpa Jang from three houses over sometimes comes to eat at our house too. Yesterday I ate at his house, though. Hee hee."

Jang-pal watched his daughter fondly.

"Hanga, did you go to the elder's house again?"

"Uh-huh. Grandpa gave me something tasty yesterday. So did the other older brothers."

"How many times have I told you not to bother the elder? But what do you mean, older brothers?"

---

[977] Namul are Korean side dishes made from seasoned vegetables or wild greens.

Jang Family Village was a small place. The few young men there had either left for other regions or joined Murim sects with dreams of making their fortunes in the martial world.

Those who remained had families of their own, so there was hardly anyone Hanga would call an older brother.

“Were they strangers?”

“Uh-huh. They were tall and handsome, and they gave me this much food. So I found Grandpa for them.”

“You found him? Were they looking for the elder?”

“I don’t know. They were just looking for Grandpa. They were cool older brothers with sticks hanging from their waists.”

“Sticks at their waists… Swords?”

Martial artists. They had to be.

Jang-pal and his wife exchanged grave looks.

To ordinary civilians like them, martial artists were objects of fear.

Only a few months had passed since the war between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect. How terrified had they been then?

Now, unidentified martial artists had appeared right next door—and their only daughter had become involved with them.

Jang-pal asked anxiously,

“What happened after that?”

“When I took them to Grandpa, he shouted.”

“D-Did you hear who those older brothers were?”

“I did, but I forgot!”

Her answer was bright and innocent, but dark clouds gathered over her parents’ hearts. Jang-pal hurriedly rose to his feet.

“I need to go. The elder may have come to harm.”

“Hanga’s father!”

“You stay here with Hanga. I’ll only sneak over and take a look, so don’t worry.”

Despite his words, he picked up the axe propped against one corner of the room. His horrified wife was about to stop him when—

“Sit down.”

“Pardon?”

“Are your ears clogged? I said sit down.”

The old man, who had been sitting quietly, rose to his feet. His bony knees cracked loudly.

“I’ve had a hearty meal. I might as well go for a stroll. Consider it payment for the food.”

Jang-pal stared blankly at him, then gave a hollow laugh.

“Elder, that’s no place for you.”

“You have it backward. It’s no place for you.”

“Please stay here. I’ll be back soon.”

“Will you be able to come back?”

The old man gazed at Jang-pal with an unreadable expression.

The moment Jang-pal met those deep, still, unfathomable eyes, his breath caught.

“If they’re even a little—just the slightest bit—unsavory, you won’t be coming back. Do you intend to leave your daughter without a father?”

The old man’s eyes flashed like a streak of light, then faded.

As if nothing had happened, he patted his lower back and held out a hand to Jang-pal.

“Give it here.”

That was all.

Yet Jang-pal handed him the axe as if under a spell.

“You’ve maintained it well. Best use this only for chopping wood.”

The old man calmly studied the sharpened blade, then grinned at Hanga. The child had sensed the change in the air, and her large eyes were already glistening.

“Why the long face?”

“I think Hanga did something wrong. Hanga was wrong.”

“Yes. This time, you were.”

Just as a miserable wail was about to burst from her, the old man continued in a voice as soft and warm as a quilt.

“So take special care not to let this happen again. Listen to your parents. Do you understand?”

“Uh-huh… But, Grandpa.”

“Go on.”

“Will you come back?”

The old man could not suppress the quiet laugh that escaped him.

“Of course. I’m old enough to chew iron. What couldn’t I do?”

At that moment, Jang-pal snapped out of his daze.

What had he been thinking, handing an axe to an old man suffering from the infirmities of age? He must have been completely bewitched.

He had to put a stop to this at once.

“Elder, please give me back the axe. This—this is ridiculous…”

Jang-pal’s words died in his throat. His mouth fell open at the unbelievable sight unfolding before him.

Crunch. Crunch.

The axe blade was breaking apart.

Each time the old man's yellow teeth moved—teeth that looked incapable of chewing even a soft chicken bone—the blade Jang-pal carefully sharpened every day snapped off piece by piece.

"W-What is this?"

"Your daughter has a fine eye for people. She was exactly right."

A conversation from earlier flashed through Jang-pal's horrified mind.

"Why are there so many clan villages around here? Less than half a shichen ago, there was something called Hong Family Village or whatever."

"Hong Family Village? Hong Family Village should be at least three hundred li[978] from here. Are you perhaps confusing it with somewhere else?"

"Do I look like some idiot who can't even remember something that happened less than half a shichen ago?"

Only then did Jang-pal realize that none of the old man's words had been lies.

He was not an ordinary old man. Someone who could walk three hundred li[979] in half a shichen and chew iron could not possibly be ordinary.

Only one kind of person could perform such extraordinary feats.

"A martial artist…"

The old man asked Jang-pal, whose legs were trembling,

"So, where are they?"

A voice brimming with joy slipped between Jang Taebo's lips.

"I'll make you the greatest divine weapon in the world."

Ding.

SYSTEM

The Quest mission has been completed.
Quest Find the Master Artisan has been successfully completed.
A linked Quest has been created.

"…"

Shit. If I'd known this would happen, I would've shown him sooner.

Hyuk Mujin looked dumbfounded too. No, on closer inspection, he looked horrified.

"Is all of that Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?"

[978] Here, *li* is the Chinese distance unit of 500 m (0.311 mi). Three hundred li is about 150 km (93 mi).
[979] Here, *li* is the Chinese distance unit of 500 m (0.311 mi). Three hundred li is about 150 km (93 mi).

I scratched my chin. What did I know? The System said it was Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, so I simply took its word for it.

“Yeah, probably.”

“You can’t just say ‘probably’!”

“Tell me about it.”

To be honest, I was flustered too.

When Jang Taebo had shown no reaction after hearing that I possessed Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, I had assumed that people in the upper circles treated Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron as basic gear.

But as it turned out…

Is it like a drink made with ten percent apple flavoring?

They called it the greatest mineral under heaven, and if people only shaved off tiny pieces to attach to a blade, it must be incredibly rare.

While everyone else used weapons containing five or ten percent Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, I could have one made from a hundred percent.

That was an enormous advantage.

My gear alone would give me a head start.

“With this—with this, I can create the masterpiece of my lifetime.”

Jang Taebo trembled all over, overcome with emotion.

It was hard to believe he was the same old man who had acted indifferent and played hard to get only moments ago. Not that I was complaining, now that everything had worked out.

“Where in the world did you obtain such an enormous amount of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?”

“That’s a secret.”

“D-Did you perhaps discover a mine containing vast deposits of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?”

Jang Taebo’s eyes flared like high beams. He had claimed he no longer needed anything, but now…

“Tell me!”

I coldly shook my head. I did not even know where the mine was, and I could not tell him the truth anyway.

“No.”

“Please! I’m begging you!”

“W-Wait, what are you doing?”

Now he was clinging to my trouser leg. The spirit of an artisan who had devoted decades to a single path blazed in his eyes.

“Please!”

“Oh, for crying out loud!”

Just as I hurriedly pried Jang Taebo’s hands away—

“Is this the house of Grandpa Jang, who lives three houses over…? Damn it. It’s rubbing off on me already. Anyway, is this Old Man Jang’s house?”

A sharp voice pierced my eardrums.

Chapter 171

The sharp, ringing voice belonged to a squat old man.

He was shorter than most elementary schoolchildren these days and dressed in grimy clothes. But more than anything else…

He's incredibly old.

I hadn't lived all that long, but in all my years, I had never seen anyone so ancient.

Just as I was thinking that, my eyes met the old man's.

"Hey!"

"Yes?"

"When an elder asks you a question, you're supposed to answer. Is this Old Man Jang's house?"

Is that the vibe that comes with experience?

The old man looked as though he could drop dead at any moment, yet his eyes were more than lively—they practically blazed. Feeling strangely intimidated, I answered.

"It is."

Jang Taebo, who had been clutching my trouser leg, awkwardly rose to his feet.

I wondered if the old man might be one of his friends from the senior center, but the wary look on Jang Taebo's face suggested otherwise.

"Who are you?"

"Just a traveler passing through. Are you Old Man Jang?"

"That's right."

"I see. I stopped by just in case."

The old man glanced around, then added,

"Though I suppose there wasn't any need."

"…"

"…"

"Then I'll be going. Once you're finished here, stop by the house where that kid lives. The child's worried about you."

With that, the old man turned around.

What the hell was that old man's deal?

As everyone stood there bewildered by his incomprehensible words and actions, Cheongpung poked me in the side.

"Munch, munch. Benefactor. Don't you think there's something strange about him?"

"…You look stranger to me. And swallow what's in your mouth before you talk."

How long is this guy going to keep chewing those dumplings? Does he have some magic jar that keeps producing more?

At my scolding, Cheongpung gulped down what was in his mouth and muttered,

“No, but there’s something strange about him.”

“Like what?”

“I don’t know. It’s just a feeling.”

“What kind of answer is th—”

Wait.

It was just a feeling?

I froze. Cheongpung might have been an eccentric, but he was also the disciple who had inherited everything from the Sword Saint and a Peak master far above me in skill.

Could he have sensed something about that old man that I couldn’t?

He looks like an ordinary old man…

There was nothing to lose by checking. In Murim, where anything could happen, it was best to tap even a stone bridge before crossing it.

Activate Qi Sense.

Ding!

SYSTEM

You have used the Skill *Qi Sense*.
You can detect targets up to Level 90 within a range of 70 jang[980].
Internal energy is consumed in proportion to range.

Whoosh.

A blue line visible only to me shot outward.

It passed through Cheongpung, Hyuk Mujin, and Jang Taebo, who were closest to me, before finally reaching the back of the old man as he slowly walked away.

A translucent holographic window sprang up above his snow-white hair.

SYSTEM

Lv. 3 Jeok Cheongang

Jeok Cheongang? Now that’s a name fit for a final boss.

[980] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Seventy jang is about 212 meters (696 ft).

But despite his impressive name, his Level was pitifully low. The old man was unquestionably an ordinary civilian who had never learned martial arts.

"Looks like you were just barking up the wrong tree…"

My voice trailed off.

The old man's leisurely steps had stopped.

His squat body slowly turned around. Though he was more than ten jang away, the strange light in his eyes made my skin prickle.

What?

My body went rigid. My heart pounded, and my fingertips twitched.

If the old man's lips had not opened at that moment, I might have summoned a weapon from my Inventory right then and there.

"Well, now…"

The corners of the old man's wrinkled mouth twitched as he stared at me. His low voice bored into my ears.

"What an interesting fellow."

The old man, Jeok Cheongang, encountered a rather interesting situation the moment he reached his destination.

Oh-ho. Well, look at these brats.

The Supreme Peak realm was an inhuman domain where one could be called a Martial God without exaggeration. He recognized the young men's martial prowess at a glance.

One was nothing special, but the other two…

Frankly, they impressed him.

At that age, they've already broken through the wall.

The one noisily chewing dumplings in front of an elder, in particular, had already reached full maturity in the Peak realm.

Would only the Elders of the Nine Sects and One Gang[981] whom I crossed paths with briefly in the past be able to compare?

As for the other one, the tall, broad fellow…

L-Look at the insolent way that bastard's staring. Maybe I should gouge his eyes out.

The young man had a face like he had seen a walking corpse. Even so, it was obvious that he possessed martial arts far beyond what his age suggested.

No one his age could stand against him.

The rear waves of the Yangtze pushed the waves before them.

[981] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations in Murim.

That was what they said. Jeok Cheongang suddenly realized that the new wave was quite large and fierce.

Large enough to swallow the entire Yangtze.

I suspected as much when they started making a fuss about Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron and all that… but they're even more interesting than I expected.

Jeok Cheongang could detect presences from dozens of jang away. He had been listening to their conversation from the moment he left Jang's house.

He also knew that the matter Jang had been worried about had not happened.

Far from being coerced, Old Man Jang appeared to be the one clinging to them.

Given their accomplishments and the fact that they'd even brought Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, could they be from the Nine Sects and One Gang? Well, either way, they clearly belong to a prestigious orthodox faction.

That was the extent of Jeok Cheongang's interest.

He had no reason to form a connection with those young men and no desire to reveal his identity.

He had done enough to repay the meal he had been given, so he intended to leave immediately.

"Then I'll be going. Once you're finished here, stop by the house where that kid lives. The child's worried about you."

Jeok Cheongang tossed out those final words and turned away.

He had already wasted a considerable amount of time. He intended to reach Taiyuan before the day was out and pay a visit to the Lower District Sect.

Of course, he had no intention of letting anyone discover his identity.

If I wrap a mask around my face and threaten them a little, they should spill everything.

But Jeok Cheongang's train of thought went no further.

The next moment, something unknown shot toward him from behind.

Whoosh.

He could neither see nor hear it.

He had only sensed it. A cold, unfamiliar presence pierced toward Jeok Cheongang's back.

An ambush?

No. He sensed none of the sticky, unpleasant killing intent that accompanied one.

Instead, it felt as natural as a breeze blowing from afar, which only made it more alien.

The unknown energy vanished the moment it touched Jeok Cheongang's back.

What in the world…?

He had lived for nearly a hundred years, yet this was the first time he had ever experienced anything like it.

Still bewildered, he turned around and immediately identified the culprit.

“Looks like you were just barking up the wrong tree…”

The young man’s mouth snapped shut the instant their eyes met. His gaze wavered, and his fingertips twitched.

As Jeok Cheongang stared at the culprit, the corners of his mouth slowly rose.

“Well, now…”

He stroked his chin, intrigued.

“What an interesting fellow.”

At the same time, his foot pushed off the ground.

In the next instant, the distance of more than ten jang between them vanished. Jeok Cheongang whispered into Jin Taekyung’s ear.

Inventory summon.

Just six syllables.

All I had to do was picture the spear and shout the words in my mind. But…

“What are you?”

The breath tickling the back of my neck made every hair on my body stand on end.

When did he—?

No, before that…

How?

He was definitely, definitely Level 3.

It was impossible to believe.

Jeok Cheongang looked as though he could drop dead at any moment, yet he was faster than anyone I had ever seen.

So fast that I did not even dare consider resisting him.

“Hey. When an elder asks you a question, you’re supposed to answer.”

“Y-Yes?”

“You call that an answer?”

A thin, wrinkled finger repeatedly poked me in the solar plexus. There was no force or internal energy behind it, yet it felt as though someone were stabbing me with a sword.

“I’m asking what you are.”

I swallowed hard. My mouth felt as dry as if someone had poured a handful of sand into it.

“I’m Jin Taekyung.”

“Not that crap. Which sect are you a disciple of?”

“Taiyuan—the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan? Are you one of those demonic, heterodox sorts?”

I nearly nodded without thinking.

The old man’s eyes had flashed when he mentioned demonic, heterodox arts. If I said yes even by mistake, he looked ready to cut my life short on the spot.

“I’m with an orthodox faction.”

“Are you? Then why are you stammering?”

“I’m telling the truth.”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan… I feel like I’ve heard of it. Or perhaps I haven’t.”

Jeok Cheongang sank deep into thought, then suddenly gave me a peculiar look.

“The more I look at you, the stranger you seem. That thing just now—it was you, wasn’t it?”

That thing just now?

His words were vague, but I immediately understood.

This old man definitely sensed Qi Sense.

How is that possible?

I had vaguely suspected as much when he reacted right away, but the realization still made my vision go dark.

Good God. A monster who can sense Qi Sense.

“Why aren’t you answering?”

I bit down hard on my lower lip.

“No.”

“How do you know what I’m talking about?”

“…”

“Hey. It was you, wasn’t it?”

“No. Anyway, it wasn’t me.”

“Oh, I like that. You’ve got some backbone. Very manly.”

Jeok Cheongang laughed heartily, then continued,

“Should I break a few bones and ask again?”

“It was me! Yes, it was me!”

“Good. Fine. Then what did you do to me?”

I hesitated.

My opponent was an old man whose instincts were every bit as sharp as his age suggested. If I lied and got caught, I would not be leaving with my body intact.

I needed to stick as closely to the truth as possible while phrasing it in a way he would find agreeable.

“You seemed like an extraordinary person, so I just…”

“A little?”

“I checked whether you had learned martial arts.”

“How?”

“Yes?”

“I asked how you did it.”

“I sent a little of my qi toward you and read yours. Something like that.”

“Ha. Is that so?”

Jeok Cheongang laughed as though amused, then clenched his fist.

“If you keep lying, I’ll break your legs. Answer me again.”

I hurriedly waved my hands.

“W-Wait. Why are you suddenly acting like this?”

“You’ve completely misjudged this old man. Do I look like some fool who can’t distinguish something like that? What I felt just now… was different. Different enough to make me think it was the dark arts.”

“What dark arts? I’m telling you, it’s real!”

This is driving me insane.

Qi Sense was certainly a cheat Skill, closer to a System function than martial arts.

Because of that, someone like Jeok Cheongang, who appeared to be a Supreme Peak master, might have sensed something alien that he had never encountered before.

The problem is, how the hell am I supposed to explain that?

“You bastard! Can’t you tell me the truth?”

Fuck this. I’m done.

I decided to lay everything out honestly.

“The truth is, I use something called the System. It’s a bit of a cheat, so it might have felt strange to you. I’m sorry.”

Jeok Cheongang remained silent for a moment.

Then he opened his mouth.

“What kind of bullshit is that?”

“…I told you exactly what happened. I figured you wouldn’t understand.”

“Have you said all you have to say?”

“There’s plenty I haven’t said. I’ve been through a lot.”

“You’ve led a turbulent life.”

“You have no idea.”

“Don’t worry. After today, your life won’t have any more twists and turns.”

“Are you planning to make it all downhill from here?”

“Why bother saying it? How about we warm you up a little before we begin?”

It happened in an instant—too fast for me, Cheongpung, Hyuk Mujin, or Jang Taebo to react.

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh and poked me in the chest with one finger.
And then…
Fwoosh!
An overwhelming wave of heat swept through my body.

Chapter 172

Jeok Cheongang wore a smug grin.

Heh heh. Have a taste of the heat, you little punk.

His fingertip carried Scorching Yang Qi refined to its pinnacle.

Though he was using only three-tenths of his internal energy, it was still far more than a fledgling who looked barely twenty could withstand.

This ought to snap him back to his senses.

Jeok Cheongang had no particular taste for tormenting youngsters, but this one needed to be taught a lesson.

The boy had been spouting incomprehensible nonsense about some “shisudaem” or whatever for a while now, and Jeok Cheongang was sick of listening to it.

I’ve controlled my strength, so if things go well, he might even avoid an internal injury.

If things went well.

Jeok Cheongang silently added that caveat as he reached out.

Tap.

The instant his bony, wrinkled finger touched the young man’s broad chest, Extreme Yang Qi surged forward like a tidal wave. Jin Taekyung sucked in a startled breath.

“Hk!”

“How is it? Feels like you’re burning up inside, doesn’t it?”

Jeok Cheongang could not help laughing when he saw the boy’s face turn bright red. The saying that a beating was the best medicine truly was an eternal truth.

“Now, stop talking nonsense and tell me the truth—”

Whooosh! Shhk!

Jeok Cheongang could not finish his sentence. Two swords flashed in like lightning, slicing through his waist and arm.

“Did it work? It worked! Cheongpung, you did it!”

Unlike Hyuk Mujin, who was celebrating with a bewildered expression, Cheongpung merely scratched the back of his head.

Before his eyes, Jeok Cheongang’s figure scattered like mist instead of spraying blood.

“Uh… Returning to Simplicity and Shifting Form and Position… I think we picked the wrong fight.”

Jeok Cheongang was already perched on a fence some distance away, laughing heartily.

“You’ve got a decent pair of eyes.”

“I grew up seeing things like that.”

“You grew up seeing them?”

Jeok Cheongang was genuinely surprised when he realized what those words implied.

Returning to Simplicity and Shifting Form and Position were both realms accessible only to Supreme Peak masters. That meant Cheongpung had grown up around a master who stood at the same level as Jeok Cheongang.

“Who is your Master?”

“My grandfather.”

“What an obtuse brat. How would this old man know who your grandfather is?”

“My grandfather always said that any man who hides behind another man’s name ought to have his balls cut off.”

“Ha ha ha! Splendid words!”

After bursting into laughter, Jeok Cheongang studied Cheongpung for a long moment.

“Can you bear the consequences of daring to point your sword at this old man?”

Cheongpung smacked his lips, looking troubled.

“But I didn’t use Sword Energy. Couldn’t you let it slide?”

“Would it have made a difference if you had?”

“Hmm. I don’t think so.”

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh. He did not know whose disciple the boy was, but he was certainly an interesting one.

“Then why did you interfere?”

Cheongpung pointed at Jin Taekyung, who stood frozen like a stone statue.

Hot steam rose in wisps from his entire body, which had been heated to a reddish hue.

“I owe him a little. How could I stand by while you bullied my Benefactor, Grandpa?”

“You must owe him quite a lot if you’re willing to risk your life.”

Cheongpung’s eyes widened.

“Are you going to kill me?”

Of course, Jeok Cheongang had no intention of killing anyone here. But he deliberately hardened his expression and lowered his voice.

“Of course.”

“Uh-oh. That won’t do. There are still so many things I haven’t tried.”

“This is the Murim. Should this old man take circumstances like that into account?”

Cheongpung thought it over before answering.

“I suppose not.”

Hyuk Mujin, who had been listening to their conversation with mounting anxiety, exploded.

“You can’t just accept that, you idiot!”

“Why not?”

“Because that old man—no, that gentleman—is going to kill us!”

“He isn’t wrong. Hmm, and besides…”

Cheongpung calmly added,

“We won’t know whether we live or die until we fight.”

“…Damn it. Fine, let’s do it. If we just sit here, Captain will beat us to death later anyway, so whatever.”

Jeok Cheongang rested his chin on one hand and gazed at the two young men.

They truly were interesting.

One was willing to stake his life because he owed someone a debt. The other grumbled even as he stepped into a fight whose outcome was obvious.

They possessed something that some called reckless bravado and others called chivalry.

People like this always die young.

That had been true forty years ago, and it would probably be true now.

That was why Jeok Cheongang had grown somewhat fond of the youngsters. At the very least, they possessed the courage to risk their lives for someone else.

Just as they were doing now.

“Then shall I teach you a thing or two?”

Jeok Cheongang slowly rose.

At the same moment, an aura as vast as a mountain erupted from his short frame and pressed down on everything around him.

Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin gripped their sword hilts, while Jang Taebo sank to the ground, his face deathly pale.

“You sit this one out.”

Jeok Cheongang flicked a finger.

Jang Taebo’s body floated over the fence as though an invisible hand had seized him and lifted him away.

Cheongpung muttered at the sight.

“Seizing an Object Through Empty Space…”

With a single gesture, the old man had lifted Jang Taebo, who was larger than most full-grown men.

It was proof that the old man possessed internal energy no weaker than Cheongpung’s grandfather.

Hyuk Mujin stared blankly and muttered,

“Shit. I’ve only ever seen that in novels.”

They were on entirely different levels.

At this moment, everything surrounding Jeok Cheongang was both his weapon and his shield. The corner of his wrinkled mouth rose slightly.

“Come.”

That was the signal.

Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin charged with all their strength.

The two knew each other’s martial arts intimately after countless duels. Their swords meshed perfectly as they launched a coordinated attack.

Whooosh!

Shhk-shhk!

Just as the two blades were about to pierce Jeok Cheongang’s flank and neck, he extended both hands.

His hands, now engulfed in white flame, closed around the blades.

“Do you think this will be enough?”

Grrrk.

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes widened.

His beloved sword, forged from the exceptionally hard Baekryeon Jeonggang, was bending. A moment later, it turned into molten metal and began dripping away.

“What the hell?”

He had poured everything into that strike, yet he had failed to leave so much as a scratch.

As he stared blankly at the blade, already half melted, Jeok Cheongang’s voice reached his ears.

“Your courage was admirable. Now get some rest.”

The next moment, Hyuk Mujin’s vision turned white. A palm struck him in the chest, and he crumpled helplessly to his knees.

“Mujin!”

“Don’t worry. He should have suffered only a minor internal injury. More importantly…”

Jeok Cheongang glanced at the blade caught in his other hand.

It had neither bent nor melted. Instead, it was wrapped in faint purple Sword Energy.

Jeok Cheongang dredged up a memory from long ago.

“Zaha Divine Technique. Are you a disciple of Huashan?”

Cheongpung answered with a punch.

The Crouching Tiger Fist, a fierce and powerful fist technique said to subdue tigers, slammed into Jeok Cheongang's chest.

Thud!

Jeok Cheongang's white eyebrows curved like a crescent moon.

"Well, look at you."

The blow should have been more than enough to shatter a man's chest, yet that was the extent of his reaction.

Cheongpung felt as though he were facing his grandfather, the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

He's strong. Overwhelmingly strong.

But he could not give up.

Cheongpung exhaled slowly and stamped his foot. The energy of the Zaha Divine Technique rippling through his body flared even more fiercely.

"Good. Show me everything you've got."

Jeok Cheongang grinned and loosened his grip on the blade.

Freed from its restraint, the sword unleashed the ultimate moves of the Plum Blossom Sword Technique.

Shiiiiing!

The sword tip moved fluidly, drawing plum blossoms through the air.

One became two. Two became five. Five became nine…

At last, twenty-four fully formed plum blossoms transformed into streaks of light and poured down toward Jeok Cheongang.

Even Jeok Cheongang could not help but marvel.

Huashan has produced an incredible talent.

And that brought one person to mind.

A figure who was practically synonymous with Huashan.

No—a figure revered by every swordsman under heaven.

"Mae Jonghak. What is your relationship with that friend of mine?"

The twenty-four plum blossoms wavered dangerously at the word *friend*.

The next moment, the Sword Energy narrowly missed Jeok Cheongang and devastated the surrounding area.

Kaboom!

Cheongpung swallowed a mouthful of the billowing dust and coughed.

"Cough, cough. You know my grandfather? Cough!"

Jeok Cheongang laughed with evident delight.

"I've met him. A very long time ago."

It had been more than forty years earlier.

The Demonic Cult's Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples had devoured half the world. As the tide of war turned against the orthodox faction, the orthodox Murim sought out even the reclusive eccentrics hidden deep within remote mountains and valleys.

That was when the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak visited Mount Jiuhua.

"Help us."

Those were his opening words.

Jeok Cheongang was surprised to receive a visit from a master who could rival him, but his answer had already been decided.

"No."

"Even with the world in danger?"

"Let's speak plainly. It's your orthodox Murim that's in danger, not the world."

Even if the ruler of the Murim changed, the world itself would remain the same. There were villains among the orthodox factions and good people within the Demonic Cult.

And Jeok Cheongang intended to remain on Mount Jiuhua forever.

Mae Jonghak sank into thought for a long while before suddenly smacking his forehead.

"Oh, now that I think about it, you're right."

"…Didn't you come here to persuade me?"

"That's that, and this is this, isn't it?"

"What kind of… If you're going to keep spouting nonsense, go home."

"Then let's settle this according to the laws of the Murim."

"Might Makes Right?"

"If I lose, I'll leave without complaint. Not only that, I'll never speak of your existence to anyone. However…"

"If you win, I have to help the orthodox Murim."

"Exactly. What do you say?"

"Draw your sword."

They fought for seven days and seven nights.

It was a battle between Huashan, which had stood as a great tree of the Murim for centuries, and the Fire Gate Clan, whose martial arts had been passed down to one successor per generation and never transmitted to outsiders.

It was a bloody struggle between two Martial Gods.

And it ended in a draw, with neither victor nor loser.

"What a pity. With martial arts like yours, why are you holed up in a mountain backwater like this?"

"Mind your own business. It's my affair. What does it have to do with you?"

"Oh. Now that I think about it, you're right."

“…Just listening to you is exhausting. What are you going to do now?”

“Honestly, I’d love to keep going, but… they crossed Gansu and Sichuan fifteen days ago. It’s a shame, but let’s leave it here this time.”

That had been fortunate for Jeok Cheongang.

If their battle had continued for even a few more days, he would have been the one to lose.

Mae Jonghak was ten years younger than him, yet he was already an astonishingly powerful master.

Without his own formidable internal energy, Jeok Cheongang would never have lasted so long.

“They may reach Anhui soon. Take care of yourself.”

“No problem. All I have to do is guard Mount Jiuhua.”

“Oh. That’s true.”

“…Please stop talking and leave.”

The Sword Saint Mae Jonghak left just like that, and the Demonic Cult’s army surged forward like a wave and swept into Anhui.

Fifteen days later, the Demonic Cultists passing through Mount Jiuhua made a grave mistake.

“Set it on fire!”

Mount Jiuhua burned, and Jeok Cheongang emerged into the world.

Not one of the thousand Demonic Cultists survived.

And people began calling him by another name.

“Then my grandfather…?”

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, merely smiled faintly instead of answering.

Chapter 173

"Then…?"

At Cheongpung's astonished expression, the Fire King Jeok Cheongang gave him a faint smile.

"Have you heard of me?"

"My grandfather mentioned you sometimes."

"Oh-ho. So that friend of mine hasn't forgotten me. What did he say?"

"He said your martial arts were strong, but your personality was… well, pretty terrible."

"…"

The truth was, Jeok Cheongang had never been particularly sociable. No, "not sociable" did not begin to cover it. He was downright awful.

He had suffered all manner of hardships as a child, leaving him with a deep-rooted distrust of people. After that, he had grown up under an eccentric Master.

So perhaps it was only natural.

"I heard you got into fights nearly every day during the Great Faction War. Apparently, you hit practically every young prodigy from the Nine Sects and One Gang at least once…"

"Ahem. Who says I hit all of them? And I was young back then. When you're young and full of energy…"

"I heard you were sixty at the time."

"Cough, cough!"

Unable to defend himself, Jeok Cheongang merely cleared his throat. Then Cheongpung added one more thing.

"But he said you were a good person once someone got to know you, so if I ever met you, I should treat you the way I treat him."

The corner of Jeok Cheongang's mouth twitched.

"Hmm. Mae Jonghak really does know me well."

Jeok Cheongang had fought in the Great Faction War for a little over a year.

It was rare for two Supreme Peak masters to fight on the same battlefield, and he had met Mae Jonghak only about ten times. Even so, they had unquestionably been close enough to call each other kindred spirits.

He did a fine job raising his grandson.

Wait a moment. Had Mae Jonghak ever married?

Jeok Cheongang quietly examined Cheongpung's face.

There was not a single feature that resembled the Mae Jonghak he remembered.

He doesn't look like a biological grandson…

Well, it did not matter.

Whether they shared blood or not, the boy was clearly his successor.

Judging by his behavior and the way he spoke, it would not be an exaggeration to say that they shared a soul rather than blood.

With a pleased smile, Jeok Cheongang spoke to Cheongpung.

“I gained a dependable grandson today. Come, give this old grandfather a formal bow.”

“What?”

Cheongpung tilted his head and asked again.

“Why?”

“…What do you mean, why?”

Caught off guard, Jeok Cheongang began to stammer.

“Didn’t Mae Jonghak tell you to treat me the way you treat him?”

“Yes.”

“You little punk, if a grandson meets his grandfather, he should give him a formal bow.”

“My grandfather doesn’t care about things like that. He said only hidebound old men obsess over empty formalities.”

“…!”

Jeok Cheongang trembled, having suddenly become a hidebound old man.

“What was this called again? I learned it recently.”

Cheongpung thought hard for a moment, then slapped his forehead.

“Oh, right. A boomer!”

“A boo… what?”

“A boomer. They say ‘boomer-brain’ means something similar.”

What? A boomer? Boomer-brain? Neither the sound nor the feel of the words was particularly pleasant.

Jeok Cheongang did not know exactly what they meant, but he understood the context well enough.

Have I been hiding in the mountains for too long?

The new waves of the Yangtze were stronger than he had imagined. Even so, he could not beat up the only grandson of his one kindred spirit…

Jeok Cheongang felt his head begin to ache and opened his mouth.

“Is that something young people are saying these days?”

“I don’t know. I only heard it for the first time recently.”

“From whom?”

“My Benefactor.”

Jeok Cheongang followed the direction Cheongpung was pointing and turned his head.

His eyes met those of a young man squinting at him.

“Hey, come here.”

Did he see me? It felt like our eyes met for a moment…

No, he didn’t. Absolutely not. I closed my eyes right away. How could he have seen me?

I trembled with my eyes shut, as if I were struggling with all my might to treat an internal injury.

Just in case, I even added a groan.

“Uuugh!”

“Hey, I said come here.”

Stay calm.

He was just making a wild guess. If I fell for it immediately, I would be Third Rate.

At times like this, a Peak master had to clench his ass and keep acting his heart out.

“Uuugh!”

“Don’t force it. I’ve seen plenty of people shit themselves doing that.”

He had a point. I relaxed slightly at Jeok Cheongang’s helpful advice.

“Huuugh!”

“Good grief, what a brat. This is the last time I’m asking. Are you coming, or should this old man come to you?”

The last time.

I could not fall for a phrase like that.

I had to hold out until the very last last.

“This old man will go, then. You’re dead today.”

“…I’ll come.”

With tears in my eyes, I opened them.

Jeok Cheongang was glaring at me, his eyes blazing like fire.

He truly looked worthy of the title Fire King.

Fuck. The Fire King.

What are you doing here, hyung[982]…?

No matter how many times I thought it over, the situation was utterly unbelievable.

[982] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man.

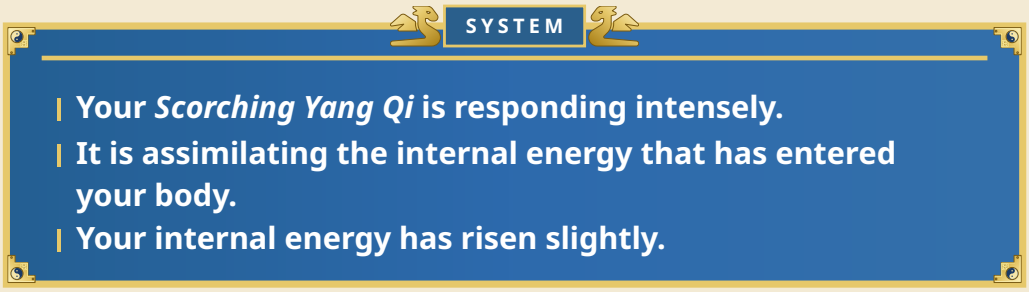
But reality did not change. That short, squat old man was the Fire King, a Supreme Peak master counted among the twenty strongest under heaven.

I had a feeling from the start.

I might have been the first person here to realize his true identity.

The moment Jeok Cheongang's internal energy surged into me, the System had delivered a telling message.

Ding.



It had happened in the blink of an eye. At first, I thought I was about to be roasted alive. But soon my stomach grew warm, as if I had just eaten a bowl of gukbap,[983] and my internal energy even increased.

What the hell is this?

At first, I was bewildered, but I figured something good was something good. The more I thought about it, though, the less I could afford to be so relaxed.

Wait. My Scorching Yang Qi came from eating the Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

Just because it was the same kind of Scorching Yang Qi, why would that make me immune to harm? I had even absorbed his internal energy.

After a brief but intense deliberation, I eventually reached a conclusion.

It was because they were of the same kind, both born from the same root.

That meant the old man belonged to the Fire Gate Clan, which passed its legacy down to a single successor in each generation. As far as I knew, the current Sect Leader was probably…

The Fire King… No way. Why would a man who had been off the radar for nearly forty years come here?

That was what I thought at the time.

They say the first of the five psychological stages cancer patients go through is denial. I was no different.

The only difference was that I reached the final stage—acceptance—in less than five minutes.

He was close friends with the Sword Saint, lived on Mount Jiuhua during the Great Faction War, and wiped out all the Demonic Cultists after they set fire to the mountain…

[983] *Gukbap* is a Korean dish of rice served in hot soup.

Fuck. He really is the Fire King.

The more I listened to Jeok Cheongang and Cheongpung's conversation, the more certain his identity became.

He had not explicitly declared that he was the Fire King, but anyone who had not figured it out by this point would have to be an idiot.

Once I finally reached the acceptance stage, a chill ran down my spine.

I'm fucked.

I pictured Jopil, dead with half his body blown away by my *One Annihilation*. I also thought of the *Nameless Sword* and the *Flame Divine Palm* martial arts manual sitting in my Inventory.

I had already gulped down the Blazing Flame Divine Pill, and it was safely stored in my dantian.

God, my stomach hurts.

Whether Jopil was that old man's disciple or not, I had a problem either way.

My thoughts in chaos, I trudged forward like an ox being led to slaughter. Jeok Cheongang raised a finger.

"I'll count to three. One."

Whoosh!

I charged forward with every ounce of strength I possessed. The Fire King looked at me as though I were the craziest bastard he had ever seen and opened his mouth.

"Hey."

"Yes!"

"You startled me! I'm not deaf, so speak softly!"

Smack!

A crisp impact left the back of my head throbbing. It was the first time I had ever been hit like that in the Murim.

Of course, I had no intention of protesting. My opponent was an irritable Supreme Peak master.

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes as I kept my mouth shut.

"Well, look at you. You're much quieter than before."

"No, I'm not."

"Don't lie to this old man. You'd have better luck deceiving a ghost. Even the way you opened your eyes was different."

Cheongpung approached with a worried expression.

"Benefactor, are you all right?"

My body is fine. My soul is dying.

I answered in a half-dead voice.

"Yes. More or less…"

"More or less?"

Without so much as a turn signal, Jeok Cheongang stuck his head in and looked me up and down.

"Hmm. Now that I think about it, why are you so fine? You should have been unable to move and forced to circulate your energy for at least half an hour."

Why am I fine? Because I absorbed the Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

But I could not say that. Under his suspicious gaze, my mouth went dry.

"You're a strange one, the more I look at you. Which sect are you from?"

"I'm from the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"The Jin Family of Taiyuan… I'm sure I've heard of it somewhere."

Jeok Cheongang furrowed his brow for a moment, then exclaimed, "Ah!"

"Was it the Blade of Flowers? That's right. That fellow Jin Baekyang was from the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Blade of Flowers Jin Baekyang.

He was the Head Elder.

I never expected that name to come up here.

Under Jeok Cheongang's demanding gaze, I licked my lips.

"That's right."

"I ran into him a few times in my travels. He was a decent fellow. He had a somewhat gloomy side, but everyone was like that back then. He was also unfailingly courteous."

All that remained to a person were their memories, especially for an old man like Jeok Cheongang, who did not have many years left to live.

But why did that memory have to be of the Head Elder?

Apparently, he remembered him quite fondly.

Then again, until recently, no one would have expected the Head Elder to do what he had done.

During the Great Faction War, his martial arts had been formidable enough to make him a leading candidate for Family Head, and he had been widely respected.

"Judging by your attainment, you carry the Jin Family of Taiyuan's blood. What is your relationship with the Blade of Flowers?"

"He's my great-uncle."

In reality, we had been locked in a relationship of killing or being killed. But I was not technically lying.

At the mention of shared blood, Jeok Cheongang's eyes softened.

"Oh-ho. Is that so?"

"Yes, sir."

"How old are you?"

“Twenty this year. I’ve just come of age.”

“You seem to have learned Scorching Yang Qi. Did the Blade of Flowers teach you?”

“…Yes.”

He had given me some instruction about two months ago at Eight Spring Gorge.

He had been so enthusiastic about it that Sword Energy had nearly split my head open.

“Your achievements are remarkable for your age. You’re far more advanced than the Blade of Flowers was in his day.”

Jeok Cheongang was even offering me compliments now.

The atmosphere had become warm and friendly overall.

Then he opened his mouth again.

“So, is he doing well?”

“Uh…”

Well, he’s doing fine in his grave, I suppose.

“His martial arts must have improved considerably by now. Should I stop by and see him while I’m here?”

“About that…”

You can visit, but you won’t be seeing his face.

The Head Elder’s grave was in one corner of the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s cemetery—in other words, the family cemetery.

The family elders had vehemently opposed it, but Jin Wikyung had pushed it through. He had felt guilty about the mistake made by his grandfather, the former Family Head.

“I suppose I should have a drink with him. It’s been a long time since we last met. Surely he won’t treat me coldly.”

I imagined Jeok Cheongang pouring liquor beside the Head Elder’s grave.

Damn it. I can’t keep this up.

I took a deep breath and opened my mouth.

“Um, there’s something I need to tell you.”

“What is it? Go ahead.”

“He passed away.”

“…What?”

“Just a couple of months ago, unfortunately.”

Jeok Cheongang was silent for a moment before muttering, “Already? He was still going strong.”

“…”

Going strong? He was over eighty.

Of course, he had possessed powerful internal energy. If he had stayed out of trouble, he might have lived another twenty years.

“What happened?”

“He fell in battle.”

“He fell in battle?”

A trace of anger appeared in Jeok Cheongang’s eyes.

“Was it the Demonic Cult bastards?”

“No. The circumstances were complicated and sensitive, so it’s difficult to explain.”

“Do you know who killed him?”

“…”

“Did you avenge him? From the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s perspective, he was the kind of bastard they could grind up and eat, bones and all, and still not be satisfied.”

Listening to him made me feel as if my bones were turning to jelly.

I lowered my head silently with a sorrowful expression. Sensing the subdued atmosphere, Jeok Cheongang stopped speaking.

Good. Perfect. Hyuk Mujin being unconscious was a stroke of genius.

If he had been awake, he would have been shooting me sidelong glances and practically shouting, *This is the culprit. He killed him.*

All right. As soon as I get out of here, I’m getting the hell away. Maybe I should just use Logout altogether.

Then, in the next moment, I realized something.

“Huh? Blade of Flowers Jin Baekyang—isn’t he the person you killed, Benefactor? Right?”

I had forgotten about that bastard.

Chapter 174

“Huh? Blade of Flowers Jin Baekyang—isn’t he the person you killed, Benefactor? Right?”

Only one thought crossed my mind.

I should’ve put a muzzle on that bastard ages ago.

Was he even human? No, he was an animal.

But it was already too late. Cheongpung was running wild like a pit bull off its leash.

“It’s a famous story. After a fierce battle, Benefactor drove his spear straight into the Blade of Flowers’s chest—bam! And the blood went splat!”

Please stop. That’s enough, you lunatic.

I had to shut him up, even now. I hurriedly opened my mouth, but before I could speak—

“I heard you even cursed at the Blade of Flowers. ‘Get your hands off me, you son of a bitch!’”

“…Where did you hear that?”

“Everyone I met seemed to know about it. When I told them I was close to Benefactor, lots of people came over and told me all kinds of things. The cook even packed me a ton of delicious food.”

No wonder he kept disappearing so often.

While staying with the Jin Family of Taiyuan, he must have wandered all over the place, eating plenty and listening to what people had to say.

And thanks to him, I’m fucked.

I swallowed hard and slowly turned my head.

Jeok Cheongang stood there with an utterly unreadable expression.

“It’s a misunderstanding.”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyebrow twitched.

“A misunderstanding?”

“Yes. Really. It truly is.”

“A misunderstanding. That’s possible. Rumors circulating through the Murim tend to get twisted and exaggerated.”

His dry voice continued.

“So you weren’t the one who killed the Blade of Flowers?”

“Uh… I was, actually. But the thing is—”

“Then there’s no need to hear any more.”

I could not finish my sentence.

Just a few steps away, Jeok Cheongang’s hands were blazing red.

Whoooosh.

I could feel it.

An overwhelming current of internal energy.

The cold shattered, and the scorching wind of a desert whipped around us. The heat forcing its way between my lips felt as though it would sear my lungs.

A memory from only a few months ago flashed through my mind.

The Flame Divine Palm?

That was it. The Flame Divine Palm.

But it was on an entirely different level from Jopil's.

It was several times stronger. Stronger, stronger, and simply stronger.

Jeok Cheongang was no longer an old man with little time left to live.

He was the Fire King incarnate.

"You defied the sacred bonds of kinship and killed the Blade of Flowers. Are you even human?"

"W-wait! There are some very profound and complicated circumstances behind that…"

That was a mistake.

Instead of babbling about circumstances, I should have blurted out that the Head Elder had betrayed the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Profound and complicated circumstances?

Shit, you have to let me explain before you decide anything.

For a moment, I had forgotten who I was dealing with.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

This was a man who had burned a thousand people to death for the simple offense of trespassing on his home and setting it on fire. Words like *profound* and *complicated* were light-years removed from him.

Whoooosh!

Damn old man…

No wonder they called him the Fire King. He was brutally straightforward and fiery as hell.

Feeling the heat of the Flame Divine Palm, I stared wide-eyed.

Is my life flashing before my eyes?

In a world slowed to a crawl, his flame-wreathed palm crept toward my chest.

If Jopil's Flame Divine Palm had been beef-bone soup, this was spicy fish stew loaded with hot green chilies.

If I took a direct hit from that, I could not guarantee I would survive.

I have to block it.

The problem was, I could not move so much as a finger.

The whole world seemed to be moving in slow motion only because my brain had registered the threat of death. Jeok Cheongang had not slowed down, and I had not gotten any faster.

Damn it.

I desperately tried to raise my hand, but it was already too late.

Jeok Cheongang's burning red palm filled my vision amid the darkness of despair.

Then—

Shiiiiing! Boom!

A streak of Sword Energy shot out of nowhere and slammed into Jeok Cheongang's hand.

Brilliant violet Sword Energy.

It was Cheongpung.

Beyond the thunderous explosion, I heard his desperate cry.

"Benefactor!"

Even Cheongpung's Sword Energy could not stop Jeok Cheongang's Flame Divine Palm. It had only slowed it for the briefest instant.

But the crossroads between life and death was always decided in that instant.

Now!

The forty-five years of internal energy coiled within my dantian stirred awake.

Scorching Yang Qi flared like wildfire and surged through countless acupoints.

Its destination was my hands.

I thrust them forward with all my strength to meet Jeok Cheongang's Flame Divine Palm.

Damn it. I don't even have time to draw a weapon.

Of all the things I could have come up with against the Flame Divine Palm, I was using my bare hands.

It was clearly insane, but it was the best insanity I could manage in this situation.

I roared from the depths of my soul.

"Cheongpung, you son of a biiiiitch!"

The instant my hands met the Flame Divine Palm—

Gooooong.

A deafening blast of splitting air erupted.

The thunderous boom seemed to split the sky.

After a brief silence, things began to change.

Fssssss.

Everything crumbled into ash and scattered through the air.

The stone wall Jang Taebo had painstakingly built ten years ago. The few trees he had planted in one corner of the yard.

All of it.

Black ash fluttered down onto the old man's white hair.

"W-what in the world…"

Jang Taebo could not stop trembling.

He had spent a long lifetime in the Murim—long enough for the mountains and rivers to have changed six times over, and then some.

He was merely a blacksmith who had never learned martial arts, but that was precisely why he had been able to meet so many people.

"I beg you. If that's what you want, I'll even give you my head!"

"Make me the finest sword under heaven."

"Are you the Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild? I was sent by the Imperial Son-in-Law."

From clueless martial artists to the leaders of renowned sects and great factions, even powerful figures from the imperial court had sought him out.

They came from every walk of life, but Jang Taebo's answer was always the same.

"If you are worthy, I will make one for you."

Jang Taebo believed that every blade had a soul.

For a blunt, rounded lump of metal to take shape, it had to endure thousands, tens of thousands, of hardships. It was bent countless times and beaten again and again. It was heated until it glowed, then cooled until it was cold.

Only once that long ordeal was over and it had finally taken shape did it gain a soul.

So it must also be my duty to choose a master worthy of the weapon.

Depending on whose hand wielded it, the weapon could become a killing blade or a life-giving blade.

Jang Taebo knew that better than anyone, which was why he never accepted a commission lightly.

One with a gentle nature. One overflowing with ambition. One determined to walk a path all his own…

No two people were alike. Countless people, each different from the next, had received weapons from him and returned to the Murim.

Some had died, while others survived.

But they all had one thing in common.

They were strong. Every last one of them.

They were masters capable of becoming the overlords of entire regions.

Strong enough to protect treasures coveted by all and use them as they saw fit.

Some had possessed martial arts that could be compared to those of the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang[984] and the Five Great Families[985].

But…

This is different. This man is different.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

The aura and martial arts erupting from that diminutive frame were beyond human.

Jang Taebo also realized that Jeok Cheongang would never need a weapon.

His martial arts have reached the heavens.

Whether he held something in his hands no longer mattered.

This was the Supreme Peak realm he had only vaguely imagined.

"Phew."

Jang Taebo released the breath he had been holding. As the strength left his body, the object tucked inside his robe slipped to the ground.

So hard and light that it was difficult to believe it was a mineral, it gave off a faint glow even in broad daylight.

"Good grief!"

It was a treasure destined to be reborn as his final masterpiece—the greatest work of his life.

Jang Taebo hurriedly picked up the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron and clutched it to his chest.

Then he froze.

As he came to his senses, he suddenly remembered something he had forgotten.

His client.

"W-wait! Stop! I said stop!"

Jang Taebo scrambled to his feet and rushed forward.

A young man lay naked at Jeok Cheongang's feet, every scrap of his clothing burned away. He was not moving at all.

"I-is he dead?"

Jeok Cheongang did not answer.

He merely looked back and forth between his hand and the young man, his face terrifyingly rigid.

"Say something!"

"…"

"Y-you…!"

---

[984] A collective name for nine major martial sects and one gang in Murim.

[985] A grouping of five major martial families in Murim.

Jang Taebo burst out in fury and was just about to examine Jin Taekyung when a clear voice stopped him.

“He’s not dead. He only suffered an internal injury and lost consciousness for a moment.”

The owner of the voice continued.

“Right, Grandpa Jeok?”

“…Yes.”

When Jeok Cheongang finally answered, his voice was hoarse.

Every word revealed his surprise and the complicated emotions roiling inside him.

“I never intended to kill him in the first place.”

Just as Cheongpung and Jang Taebo sighed in relief, Jeok Cheongang added one short sentence.

“Until now, that is.”

“…!”

“…!”

“Don’t worry. I’ll decide what to do after I hear the full story.”

Jeok Cheongang stared strangely at the fallen Jin Taekyung.

“I have a great many questions for this boy.”

The words sounded almost threatening, prompting Jang Taebo to step forward.

Even witnessing the Fire King’s martial prowess firsthand had not shaken the resolve hardened by his long years.

“That sounds as though you intend to torture him.”

“I have no taste for that. But if it proves necessary…”

“Do you have any idea who that young man is? You may be a master counted among the Ten Kings, but if you think you can make an enemy of the entire Shanxi Murim and emerge unscathed, you are gravely mistaken!”

Jeok Cheongang gave a short laugh.

“There were once men who swallowed half the world with an army of one hundred thousand. Do you think I feared them?”

“…!”

Jang Taebo was left speechless.

That was right. His opponent was the Fire King.

The old monster of Mount Jiuhua who had once fought alone against the Demonic Cult when it sought to rule the world.

Orthodox, unorthodox, or demonic—he belonged to none of them.

He had thrown his own weight onto the scales of war.

The reason was simple.

They had invaded his territory.

Jeok Cheongang stared at Jang Taebo with reddish eyes.

“I have one request. Please don’t ask anyone for help. I have no desire to burn down the Shanxi Murim at my age.”

He meant it.

And he possessed the power to make his words reality.

“Understood?”

“I-I’ll bear it in mind.”

“A wise decision.”

Jeok Cheongang grinned and turned away.

All the strength suddenly left Jang Taebo’s legs. As he began to fall, Cheongpung caught him and asked,

“Where are you going?”

“There’s an inn where you lot were staying, isn’t there? I’ll go ahead. Follow me.”

Cheongpung watched Jeok Cheongang’s back slowly recede and muttered plaintively,

“Whew. Grandfather was right. He really does have a strange personality.”

He said it so calmly that Jin Taekyung would have reached for a muzzle if he had heard.

Cheongpung turned to Jang Taebo and bowed deeply.

“Sorry for causing you so much trouble. We’ll be going now.”

Then he tucked Jin Taekyung under one arm and Hyuk Mujin under the other before trotting briskly away.

Jang Taebo stood there for a long while as though bewitched by a ghost.

Before long, he remembered the crucial fact that had momentarily slipped his mind.

Fire King, you goddamn old bastard.

There had to be a limit to this kind of outrageous behavior.

He had burned everything down, leaving nothing but the foundation stones.

Jang Taebo stared blankly at the ash drifting all around him, then let out a deep sigh.

“Fuck. This place is done for too.”

That was the moment his sweet retirement came to an end.

Chapter 175

In a shabby guest room, a diminutive old man silently gazed down at the young man lying on the bed.

Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Though he had yet to regain consciousness, Jin Taekyung's face looked peaceful. At a glance, he might have been sound asleep.

He took the Flame Divine Palm, and this is all he suffered?

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue inwardly.

The technique had been executed by his own hand—a Supreme Peak martial art.

He had held back, but even so, its power was not something a young punk who had only just broken through to Peak should have been able to withstand.

There was only one possible answer, and Jeok Cheongang already knew what it was.

This boy has cultivated the same kind of Scorching Yang Qi as I have.

But not all Scorching Yang Qi was the same.

In some ways, internal energy resembled a weapon. Its essence was one, but it could take many forms.

Advanced cultivation techniques each displayed their own distinct characteristics, like Huashan's Zaha Divine Technique.

The same was true of the Fire Gate Clan, which Jeok Cheongang currently led as Sect Leader.

There's no way this boy learned the Fire Gate Divine Technique.

For hundreds of years, the Fire Gate Clan had strictly upheld its tradition of passing its teachings down to a single successor.

As the current Sect Leader, Jeok Cheongang knew better than anyone that nothing had ever leaked during that succession.

And yet, Jin Taekyung bore traces of his school…

It must have been that, after all.

The Blazing Flame Divine Pill.

No matter how he considered it, that was the only answer.

Jeok Cheongang smiled bitterly, his expression so lonely that anyone who knew him would have doubted their own eyes.

"So this is how it ended."

His aged voice echoed hollowly through the shabby guest room, then faded away.

For a long while, Jeok Cheongang's gaze seemed to pursue something that could neither be seen nor grasped. At last, it settled on Jin Taekyung's face.

His features were badly contorted, as though he were trapped in a nightmare.

“What is this old man to do with you…?”

At that moment, Jin Taekyung muttered something like a groan.

“Mmm… kimochiii.[986]”

“…”

Kimo… what?

Jeok Cheongang could not understand the word, but something about hearing it made him deeply uncomfortable.

He watched Jin Taekyung twitch over and over, murmuring “kimochi” all the while, then slowly shook his head.

What a strange fellow.

He left only after “kimochi” turned into “yamete.”[987]

Unable to endure any more, Jeok Cheongang fled the room with goose bumps prickling across his forearms.

…Is this some form of dark art after all?

His suspicions deepened.

When I opened my eyes, I saw a shabby ceiling.

A reddish oil lamp flickered nearby, and darkness had fallen beyond the window.

A sigh of relief escaped me before I knew it.

“Pheeeew.”

I was alive.

I had suffered a minor Internal Injury, but I was grateful it was no worse than that.

No, considering that my opponent had been the Fire King, it was nothing short of a miracle.

Had he really not meant to kill me?

No matter what I tried, I was no match for the Fire King. The same went for Cheongpung.

And yet, here I was, lying on a bed…

“Are you awake?”

“Gah!”

I leaped up like a startled carp.

Something crouched in a dark corner had slowly risen to its feet.

“You scared me, you crazy bastard!”

Hyuk Mujin replied gruffly.

---

[986] *Kimochi* is Japanese for “feeling”; in this context, it means “that feels good.”

[987] *Yamete* is Japanese for “stop it.”

“Why are you so surprised? It’s not as if this is your first time seeing my face.”

“Have you looked at your face? You think anyone could get used to that?”

“What’s wrong with my face? I’m handsome enough. My parents even worried about me when I was little.”

“Because they thought you’d have trouble getting through life with that face?”

“No. They were worried I’d be kidnapped because I was too pretty for a boy.”

Was he out of his mind?

With looks like his, his parents should not have worried about him being kidnapped. They should have worried he would grow up to become the kidnapper.

“…Tell them they can stop worrying.”

“I’ll tell them later.”

Hyuk Mujin shuffled toward me, then gasped and collapsed onto the floor.

“Ah, aagh! Hold on.”

“What? What’s wrong?”

His face twisted in pain.

“A cramp. I-I’ve got a cramp.”

“…You’ve really done one thing after another today. Are you sure you’re a martial artist?”

“That can happen when you sit still for too long. And whose fault is it that I was stuck in that corner?”

“How is that my fault?”

“You kept making weird noises. Gimokji, yamakdae.”

The words were carved into my soul.

They were beyond familiar. They felt like old friends. I flinched and asked,

“…I said that?”

“Yes. It gave me goose bumps, so I went outside. Then Great Hero Jeok told me to get back in here and sit quietly unless I wanted to burn to death. He said to report to him the moment you woke up.”

Hyuk Mujin continued with an aggrieved expression.

“He said it might be some kind of dark art, so I should keep my ears covered. But you wouldn’t stop. You just kept going, ‘Oh? Ahh, gimokji, gimokji…‘”

“…That’s enough, you bastard.”

This was the greatest humiliation of my life.

No wonder I had felt so electrified when I woke up. I must have been having a pretty good dream.

Just in case, I discreetly slipped a hand beneath the blanket.

Hmm. Clean. No problems.

With one problem taken care of, it was time to turn my attention to another.

In terms of importance, it was incomparably greater than the first.

My life was at stake, after all.

“Where’s that old geezer?”

There was no need to explain who I meant. Hyuk Mujin lowered his voice.

“He’s downstairs, drinking and carousing with Cheongpung.”

“He is? For how long?”

“I’m not sure. I only woke up a little while ago myself, but I asked the server, and he said they’d already been at it for more than three shichen.[988]”

I did not even need to focus my internal energy.

My hearing had grown sharper after I reached Peak, and it carried the drunken shouts and singing from downstairs straight to my ears.

Listen to them having the time of their lives.

One was an old man who attacked first and asked questions later. The other was an oblivious idiot who had barged in and caused this whole disaster.

I wanted to smash those villains’ heads in with a liquor bottle and shout, “Justice has been served!” But I held myself back.

…More precisely, I had no choice but to restrain myself.

“Phew.”

Being powerless was a sin. A sin.

As I let out a deep sigh, Hyuk Mujin cautiously spoke up.

“Captain.”

“What?”

“I think we should head downstairs soon.”

“Why the hell would I go down there?”

“Great Hero Jeok said to bring you down as soon as you regained consciousness…”

“Great Hero, my ass. How is that old man a Great Hero?”

“You’d call him Great Hero if he were standing in front of you.”

“…”

He had me there.

But obeying and going downstairs would be no different from leaping straight into a tiger’s jaws.

I began pulling on the clothes draped over the table at the speed of light.

“What are you doing?”

“Getting ready to bolt.”

“What?”

“I said I’m running away. Why? You coming?”

Hyuk Mujin grabbed my arm in alarm.

---

[988] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; three shichen is about six hours.

“Why are you running away?”

“That old geezer could lose his temper and burn me to death at any moment. If you were me, wouldn’t you run?”

“Is this about what happened earlier?”

“If by that, you mean the Head Elder?”

“Yes. If that’s what you’re worried about, Cheongpung and I already…”

I firmly cut him off.

“You must have explained everything ages ago. The misunderstanding should be cleared up by now.”

“Oh, you know?”

“Do you think I’m an idiot?”

I had passed out around noon, so at least half a day had gone by. No matter how hot-tempered Jeok Cheongang was, he must have investigated enough to learn the truth.

Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin would have done their best to clear up the misunderstanding as well.

Hyuk Mujin tilted his head.

“Then isn’t everything fine? You have no reason to run.”

Every second counted.

Pretending to rummage through my clothes, I quickly pulled an item from my Inventory and waved it at him.

“Here’s your reason.”

Flame Divine Palm

Hyuk Mujin examined the cover of the weathered martial arts manual and muttered,

“Ah, shii…”

“All right, here’s a question. What exactly is the relationship between Jopil, who possessed the Fire Gate Clan’s Flame Divine Palm manual, and Jeok Cheongang?”

“…”

“You’re starting to see it too, aren’t you? I’d bet my wrist and my entire fortune that they were master and disciple. What are you willing to bet?”

Hyuk Mujin bet nothing.

Instead, he desperately spread the wings of an imagination full of dreams and hope.

“W-wait a second. The two of them might not be master and disciple.”

“If not master and disciple, then what? Father and son? Considering they both have such shitty tempers, that actually sounds plausible too. Right?”

“Jopil might have stolen Great Hero Jeok’s belongings.”

I snorted hard enough to nearly launch a booger out of my nose.

“You think the Fire King is some harmless old man from the neighborhood? Who would dare steal from that geezer?”

The Fire King had killed a thousand Demonic Cultists because they set fire near his home.

Jopil might have been crazy, but unless he had gotten Botox injected into his liver,[989] he could not even have dreamed of doing such a thing.

After a moment’s hesitation, Hyuk Mujin nodded.

“…Fine. Let’s say Jopil was his Disciple.”

“I’m telling you, they were definitely master and disciple. And if you aren’t coming, let go of me. I’m busy.”

Hyuk Mujin ignored me and stubbornly continued.

“Even if Jopil was Great Hero Jeok’s Disciple, we were only doing our duty. Jopil was the one who attacked us and tried to kill us first.”

“Right. You and Cheongpung will be safe either way, so tell him that for me. I’ve got to get going.”

“Captain!”

“Now, Mujin. Let’s assume you’re right. Let’s say that foul-tempered old man admits his Disciple was at fault and lets the matter go. It’ll never happen, but let’s say he does.”

I peeled his hand away from my arm one finger at a time and asked,

“Then we’d still have to return everything Jopil stole, wouldn’t we?”

Hyuk Mujin nodded vigorously.

“Of course. If we kept it, we’d be asking to burn to death.”

“So what do you think would happen if we told him we couldn’t return it?”

“What? Captain, are you saying you want the Flame Divine Palm for yourself…?”

“Am I insane? Living a long and uneventful life is my philosophy. That’s why I even make my dumps thin and long on purpose!”

Under normal circumstances, he would have made a disgusted face and complained about my dirty talk. But now, he merely kept gulping dryly.

“Then what’s the problem?”

“The problem is that the Flame Divine Palm manual wasn’t the only thing Jopil had.”

I held up three fingers and began folding them down one by one.

“One, the Flame Divine Palm. Two, the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron sword. And finally, three…”

“The Blazing Flame Divine Pill.”

[989] In Korean, the liver is associated figuratively with courage. Botox injected into it is an absurd image of someone gaining enough nerve to attempt the theft.

Hyuk Mujin's jaw had already dropped at the mention of the Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron sword. Now he looked at me uncertainly.

"…Do you mean that thing from back then? The one that massively boosts your internal energy but makes your body burst into flames?"

"Yeah. The one I was planning to give you along with the Flame Divine Palm manual a long time ago."

"Where is it now? Where's that thing?"

"Mujin."

My eyes glistening, I gazed out the window toward the north—the direction of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

"Remember when we went to the Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

"Why are you bringing that up all of a sudden?"

"The Red Wind Band Leader was stronger than I expected. How was I supposed to beat someone who'd defeated Cheol Mubaek and even Jin Mukyung?"

"H-hold on. Then, back then…?"

"Yeah. It worked like a charm."

With the emotions of a woman three weeks pregnant who had just checked a pregnancy test, I stroked my stomach.

"I put it in here. The Blazing Flame Divine Pill."

"…"

"They say it's a secret divine elixir of the Fire Gate Clan. If I want to return it, I'll have to cut open my stomach and drain the blood."

"…"

"So stop holding me back. I'm casting off every shackle and restraint in this world and setting out to find a way to survive…"

At that moment, Hyuk Mujin moved with greater agility than ever before.

Tap-tap-tap—whoosh!

Clutching his ever-present satchel to his chest, he launched himself through the wide-open window.

In that moment, I saw a bird.

That bastard.

How dare he try to escape before me?

And he had even taken the satchel containing our silver nyang[990] and food!

"Hey, Hyuk Mujin!"

By the time I hissed the words after him, it was already too late.

Hyuk Mujin glanced back at me with the serene eyes of a man who had attained enlightenment.

---

[990] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of currency; here it refers to silver money.

Then his body dropped straight down.

“Goddammit.”

I had to get out of there too.

I dashed to the window and was just about to throw myself outside when—

Crack! Thud!

Hyuk Mujin, who had been sprinting away for all he was worth, suddenly crumpled as though he had been shot.

The object that struck him squarely in the temple was one I knew very well.

“…A chicken bone?”

The next moment, an aged voice rose from below.

“You stupid fool. Can’t you tell a chicken from a duck?”

Step. Step.

A small shadow swayed in the light of the lantern hanging by the inn’s entrance.

A wrinkled face suddenly appeared. It looked up at me, my body draped over the window, and grinned.

“Where were you going?”

After witnessing 14,000,605 possible futures,[991] I arrived at the most appropriate answer.

“To the privy.”

“Do you want to shit blood?”

“No.”

Yeah. I knew that would not work.

[991] The number alludes to Doctor Strange viewing 14,000,605 possible futures in *Avengers: Infinity War*.

Chapter 176

I feel like I've gone back to high school.

Like I got caught by the school disciplinarian while trying to sneak out of evening self-study.[992] Of course, the despair I felt back then was nothing compared to this.

The person holding my ear right now wasn't a school disciplinarian.

He was the Fire King.

Crack.

"Ah! Aaaagh! It hurts! Something just made a weird noise in my ear!"

Jeok Cheongang glared at me.

"Shall I make sure you never hear another sound?"

"…"

Judging by everything he had said and done so far, he was more than capable of following through.

I clamped my mouth shut and let Jeok Cheongang lead me along by the ear.

"Sit."

"Yes, sir."

I sat on a crude wooden chair and looked around.

The old inn was dark and gloomy. The owner was nowhere to be seen, and a server who looked barely twenty sat dozing at a table near the entrance.

Damn it. There aren't even any other customers.

I must have been unconscious for longer than I thought. There were only four people on the first floor.

The dozing server, Jeok Cheongang, me—and Cheongpung, already dead drunk and sprawled face-down on the table, drooling.

It was the perfect place to die without anyone being the wiser.

No. They say that even in a tiger's den, you'll survive as long as you keep your wits about you.

Even so, I needed some kind of life insurance, just in case.

Unfortunately, the only brake capable of stopping Jeok Cheongang was currently fast asleep and snoring.

Cheongpung, you need to wake up if I'm going to survive this.

I was carefully stretching my leg beneath the table, preparing to step on Cheongpung's foot, when—

"Let him sleep."

"Huh?"

"I said leave him alone. Don't bother the boy when he's sleeping."

---

[992] Evening self-study is a supervised after-school study period common in South Korean high schools.

At this point, he might as well have been a ghost.

I hadn't made a sound or even moved noticeably, yet he knew exactly what I was doing beneath the table.

"Your answer?"

"…I'll stay still."

"You're not entirely clueless, I see. You might live a long life yet."

Jeok Cheongang muttered something that could have been either praise or an insult, then tilted the liquor bottle.

As the empty cup slowly filled, the cheap liquor's sharp scent stung my nose.

"I have something to ask you."

"I'll explain everything in detail about the Head Elder—no, my great-uncle."

"I've already heard. He committed more than enough crimes to deserve death. He was a fairly sharp fellow once, but time has ruined a lot of people…"

Jeok Cheongang downed his drink in one gulp and muttered bitterly,

"That child was like that, too."

"…"

"Where did you meet him?"

The question came out of nowhere, but I understood immediately.

The "child" Jeok Cheongang had just mentioned was Jopil.

He already knew that Jopil and I were connected. The worst possible situation had become reality.

"If you're thinking of lying, you'd better abandon the idea now. You'll end up telling the truth anyway."

Jeok Cheongang's voice sank like an abyss, sending a shiver down my spine.

There was no point in lying or making excuses anymore. Right now, he was the prosecutor, the defense attorney, and the judge who could hand down any sentence he pleased.

Damn it.

My parched mouth tasted bitter. He wasn't even releasing Scorching Yang Qi, yet I was so thirsty I could barely speak.

"Give me a drink too."

"You cheeky bastard."

Despite saying that, Jeok Cheongang readily filled my cup.

I hurriedly gulped down the strong liquor, and only then could I breathe again.

Right. It wasn't over yet. The more dangerous the situation, the more I needed to keep my wits about me if I wanted to escape it.

I took a deep breath and began.

"It was about two months ago. That's when I met Jopil."

“Jopil?”

“Yes. One Question, One Kill, Jopil. He was a fairly famous wandering martial artist.”

“Judging by his alias, he probably wasn’t famous for anything good.”

“…You could say that.”

He hadn’t just been bad. He had been practically insane.

Back then, I had seen Jopil as nothing more or less than a man obsessed with killing. He had genuinely enjoyed it.

“Is this his face?”

Jeok Cheongang pulled a sheet of paper from inside his robe.

It was so old that it had yellowed with age and was crumpled all over, but the young man’s face drawn on it was still easy to recognize.

“Is that Jopil when he was young?”

“It seems it was him after all. So that’s what became of him.”

His words sounded more like a monologue than an answer to my question.

After remaining silent for a while, Jeok Cheongang suddenly spoke again.

“More than twenty years ago, a terrible epidemic swept through Anhui Province. Countless commoners died, and even more children were left orphaned. He was one of them.”

The moment had come for Jopil’s true identity, unknown to everyone, to be revealed. Depending on what Jeok Cheongang said next, my future would be decided.

I held my breath and listened.

Jeok Cheongang continued slowly. As the clear liquor rippled in his cup, memories of those days rose vividly to the surface.

“He was a child struggling desperately to survive. Even while a dozen or so people surrounded him and trampled him, he shoved a dirt-covered dumpling into his mouth.”

“…”

“I liked the fierceness in his eyes, and I pitied him too. I gave him the name Jangcheon—Vast Sky.”

That was how Jangcheon came to live in a hut deep within Mount Jiuhua.

He was the first outsider to set foot there in the fifty long years since Jeok Cheongang had seen his Master off.

“At first, he knew nothing. It wasn’t until a year later that he realized I was a martial artist. Soon afterward, he began begging me to teach him martial arts.”

To an orphan with no one in the world, who had lived amid contempt and hunger, martial artists might as well have been beings from the heavens.

The boy wanted to become a martial artist and change his life. That was why he desperately clung to the old man who had saved him.

“Please accept me as your Disciple.”

“No.”

“Master!”

“Master? Who said I was your Master? You lack both the physique and martial talent to learn our sect’s arts.”

“I’ll do it. I’ll find a way to prove myself. Even if it kills me, I won’t disappoint you, Master!”

“…Don’t be ridiculous.”

Jeok Cheongang thought Jangcheon would not last long.

But the boy’s determination was far more tenacious than he had expected. For an entire year, Jangcheon tried to persuade him every single day. Eventually, he even went so far as to injure himself and refuse food.

Each time, Jeok Cheongang was the one left sweating bullets.

“You fool. Why would you do something like this?”

“I want to learn martial arts. Please accept me as your Disciple.”

“…I can’t.”

“Is it because I’m lacking?”

“It is an unavoidable decision if I am to continue the sect’s lineage. This will be difficult for you too.”

“No matter how difficult it is, I can endure it!”

“No. If you insist on being this stubborn, I’ll have no choice but to send you down the mountain. Is that what you want?”

In truth, Jeok Cheongang was the one who did not want them to part.

With the infirmities of old age creeping up on him, it seemed he had grown lonely for human company. A year had been more than enough time for him to grow attached to the scarred, taciturn boy who had endured far too much for his age.

But…

“Then do it. I’m destined to die anyway, aren’t I?”

“What?”

“If I can’t serve you as my Master, I’ll kill myself. No—kill me now. Kill me with the same hand that saved me.”

“You little—!”

What was so important about martial arts?

Seeing Jangcheon ready to throw away his own life for them, Jeok Cheongang felt hurt and furious.

But at the same time, another thought occurred to him.

“His martial talent and physical aptitude may have been lacking, but with tenacity like that, I thought he was bound to achieve Great Completion[993] one day.”

Jin Taekyung, who had been listening quietly, asked with an uneasy expression,

“That kind of tenacity… Is that why you accepted him as your Disciple?”

“Yes.”

Jeok Cheongang added with a sigh,

“It was a mistake.”

That was the most painful mistake he had made in all the hundred years since his birth.

“For several years, everything went smoothly. He improved so quickly that the concerns I’d had before accepting him as my Disciple seemed foolish.”

Jangcheon followed his Master’s instructions faithfully.

No—it was closer to absolute obedience.

He swung his sword like a madman all day long and devoted himself to training his stamina. Even when learning the smallest, most basic techniques, he poured his entire being into them as though he were practicing the greatest martial art under heaven.

With his Disciple training with such passion and devotion, Jeok Cheongang could not help but be deeply moved. He did everything in his power to help Jangcheon grow.

Jangcheon’s talent and physical aptitude were only slightly above average, but Jeok Cheongang gradually improved his constitution by cleansing his sinews and washing his marrow.

A Master and Disciple who trusted and relied on each other.

Remarkable achievements.

Everything seemed to be going perfectly.

“The problem came afterward.”

The old man remained old, but the boy grew into a young man.

Yet his martial arts failed to develop along with his body. Jangcheon grew furious with himself after spending years making no progress, and eventually, something happened.

“I still remember it clearly. I had more trouble sleeping than usual that night, so I was sitting on a rock when he came up from below. He’d been out of sight for several days, claiming he was in closed-door cultivation.[994]”

Jin Taekyung tilted his head.

“What do you mean, he came up from below?”

---

[993] Great Completion is a stage of mastery in martial arts training.

[994] Closed-door cultivation is a period of secluded martial arts training.

“He had gone to the village. The wind carried the musk courtesans use.”

“Oh. A pleasure house?”

“I understood. He had spent more than ten years learning nothing but martial arts, barely ever leaving the mountain. What could I say when his own Master had been of so little help and cared only for his own cultivation?”

At the time, Jeok Cheongang had been immersed in training to open his upper dantian.

Opening the upper dantian meant entering the Martial Extremity realm. It would not only raise his martial arts to another level, but also treat the infirmities of old age that were steadily eating away at him.

“But it wasn’t easy. It required lengthy preparation, time, and enlightenment.”

As a result, Master and Disciple gradually began seeing less of each other.

Jeok Cheongang believed that his Disciple, who had always worked so hard, would attain enlightenment on his own, so he focused on cultivating his upper dantian.

He noticed Jangcheon’s trips down the mountain only on the occasional days when the wind carried a mixture of unfamiliar scents.

“Then one day, a visitor came.”

“A visitor?”

“The Azure Sky Sword King. I had never seen his face before, but I recognized him immediately. He was exactly as I’d heard.”

Jin Taekyung’s jaw dropped.

“The Azure Sky Sword King? One of the Ten Kings?”

“Yes. He was also the Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family.”

“Why did he come?”

Jeok Cheongang tilted the liquor bottle without a word.

He had already emptied several bottles by himself, yet his mind only grew clearer. So too did the words the Azure Sky Sword King had spoken when he appeared without warning.

“These days, the brats in my family have been throwing a fit. There’s some vicious bastard running wild in Anhui, but they say they can’t catch him. They begged me so desperately that I had no choice but to come see you.”

Jeok Cheongang had been bewildered.

The Namgung Family’s influence in Anhui was immense.

If even their power had proven insufficient, to the point that the Azure Sky Sword King himself had to step in, then just how powerful was this bastard?

“Then why did you come to me? Are you saying the bastard is some kind of Martial God?”

“If he were a Martial God, he wouldn’t be killing only innocent women and mediocre wandering martial artists. I saw him once from a distance, but I let him go.”

“What does that—”

“A Master should correct his Disciple’s mistakes, shouldn’t he?”

Not long after the Azure Sky Sword King left, Jeok Cheongang stood absentmindedly on the rock and caught a scent carried on the wind.

It was the smell of blood.

Chapter 177

Why hadn't I known?

Perhaps it was the faith I had placed in the Disciple I'd raised as my own flesh and blood. Perhaps it was indifference. But the scent of blood had unmistakably clung to Jangcheon as he staggered up the mountain that day.

"Where have you been?"

"Ah, Master."

His eyes were flushed with drink—and something else.

"I went down to the village for a little while. I've been feeling restless lately, so I had a drink."

"Drinking. Was that all?"

"It's a little embarrassing to say. Hahaha! I'm sorry you had to see me like this."

The pungent musk courtesans used stung Jeok Cheongang's nose. But it was merely a veil meant to conceal the truth.

Beneath it, he could smell the faint scent of blood. The smell of death. The smell of a killer—a scent he had forgotten since the Great Faction War.

"You went to a pleasure house…?"

"As expected, I can't fool you, Master. Yes. This useless Disciple was troubled, so I sought the company of women."

The Disciple he had not seen in so long had become a completely different person.

The taciturn, unsmiling boy was gone. In his place stood a smooth-talking killer who concealed his murders without a trace of concern.

"But what brings you out at this late hour? Have you made any progress in your closed-door cultivation?"

"…It had been so long since I'd seen your face. I was waiting for you."

He had apparently murdered dozens of innocent commoners in horrific ways.

His Disciple had committed a crime that made heaven and earth furious. The right thing to do would have been to sever his Sinews and Meridians and cripple his dantian at once. That was what a Master should do.

But—

"I see. I'm glad to see you too, Master."

At Jangcheon's faint smile, Jeok Cheongang found himself unable to speak. He felt neither anger nor betrayal. Something simply welled up from deep inside him, choking off his words.

In the end, there was only one thing he could say.

"It's late. Go get some rest."

Jin Taekyung listened to Jeok Cheongang's story with disbelief written across his face.

“Wait. That’s it?”

“I wanted to believe in that child.”

“You already knew. You knew Jopil—or rather, Jangcheon—was lying.”

“I knew.”

“And you still let the bastard go?”

“Yes. Even so.”

The old man continued in a weary voice.

“Do you have any blood relatives?”

“Yes.”

“I have none. As far back as I can remember, I was alone. He was the same.”

Jeok Cheongang looked down at his hands. Age spots and wrinkles covered them, each one bearing the imprint of the years.

“My Master was a strict man. His training was harsh and painful, but as a child, I even liked that. I was happy simply knowing that someone cared about me and was there beside me. My Master was the only person I could rely on.”

But his time with his Master had been brief. Jeok Cheongang was left alone once more, and over the years, his loneliness slowly grew numb.

Until he met a child in the marketplace, fighting desperately to protect a single dumpling.

“I was the only person that child could rely on. Even if all under heaven pointed fingers at him, I had to believe in him.”

At some point, Jangcheon had become more than a Disciple to Jeok Cheongang.

He was his only son and his grandson. They shared no blood, but Jeok Cheongang loved him more deeply than family.

“But what that child did was too horrible. I had to make him stop. One way or another.”

Before that, however, he wanted to see his Disciple’s atrocities with his own eyes.

The fact that the Azure Sky Sword King had come in person meant that all the circumstantial and physical evidence was already in hand. But that alone was not enough.

“So I began following him in secret.”

From that day on, Jeok Cheongang followed his Disciple. Evading Jangcheon’s notice was easy, since he had yet to break through to the Peak realm.

Once, twice, ten times…

With each pursuit, the despair Jeok Cheongang had initially felt began to fade.

Like any other wastrel, Jangcheon merely visited pleasure houses, drank, and embraced women. When he returned to his hut flushed with liquor, he became a martial artist once more and diligently resumed his training.

Nothing seemed amiss.

“Then a thought occurred to me. Perhaps there had been some mistake. Perhaps the Namgung Family and the Azure Sky Sword King had misjudged him.”

Jin Taekyung stared at him incredulously.

“I think you’re the one who misjudged him, Sir Jeok.”

Jeok Cheongang laughed hollowly.

“Yes. I did. Like a fool, I desperately turned away from the truth.”

“So did you eventually see it for yourself?”

“…”

Jeok Cheongang silently raised the bottle and drank straight from it.

The ceiling looked blurry, not because the liquor was strong, but because the memory of that day had returned with perfect clarity.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

In a back alley of the red-light district, beneath the heavy darkness of night, muffled groans mingled with spurts of blood.

The back of the masked man stabbing and prodding someone’s limbs with a sharp dagger was more familiar than anything—and more foreign than ever.

“…Jangcheon.”

At the quiet call, the hand gripping the dagger abruptly froze. The masked man slowly turned, and his eyes met Jeok Cheongang’s.

At the sight of his Master after so long, the Disciple’s eyes curved into crescents.

“Ah, Master.”

“What… What are you doing?”

“What do you mean? Exactly what you see.”

Jangcheon grinned and drove the dagger down.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

The middle-aged man, his limbs bound, writhed in agony.

“Stop at once!”

“Why should I?”

“…W-What did you say?”

“It’s been a long time since I came down here, and all kinds of people are running wild. Wandering martial artists swaggering around because they know a few Third Rate martial arts, merchants with fat bulging from their bodies, and women whose only property they can sell is their own bodies. What a madhouse.”

Jangcheon flashed a white smile.

“This man is just one of them. What difference does it make if I kill one such person? He’s nothing more than a two-legged beast with no reason to live.”

Everything felt like a dream to Jeok Cheongang. The hope he had clung to while watching his Disciple for the past four months vanished like a bursting bubble.

“Why… Why would you do this?”

“Because I’m strong.”

Jangcheon continued, his voice brimming with excitement.

“Might makes right. Didn’t you teach me that, Master? Murim—no, the entire world—is like that. The weak die at the hands of the strong.”

“You killed innocent people for no better reason than that?”

“Innocent? How could you possibly know they were innocent, Master?”

“Then what terrible crimes did the people you killed commit?”

Jeok Cheongang wanted them to have deserved death.

He wanted them to have been corrupt merchants who sucked the lifeblood from others, or vicious ruffians who murdered as casually as they ate—not simple commoners who knew nothing of the world and spent their lives toiling like oxen.

But…

“How should I know?”

“…!”

“Who in this world lives without sin? They were simply unlucky. The same goes for this man who happened to catch my eye.”

The world seemed to recede before Jeok Cheongang’s eyes.

The Disciple he loved like his own flesh and blood had already crossed a river from which there was no return.

Those who reached the far bank never came back. They lived out the rest of their days as blood-soaked killing fiends.

“Jangcheon.”

“Yes, Master.”

The face of the scrawny child he had met in the marketplace more than a decade ago overlapped with that of the blood-drenched young man before him.

“What in the world made you like this?”

“What do you mean?”

“You… You weren’t this kind of child. The weak die at the hands of the strong? Have you forgotten the person you once were, struggling desperately just to survive?”

“I haven’t forgotten. That’s why I am who I am now.”

“No. You were kind and diligent…”

“Master.”

Jangcheon gently cut him off.

It was the first time the Disciple had ever interrupted or contradicted his Master. But now, even open mockery lingered at the corners of Jangcheon’s mouth.

“I remember the day I first met you as clearly as if it were yesterday. I had gone hungry for days and was wandering the marketplace when I found a dirt-covered dumpling. Even as boys no better off than I was trampled me, I kept forcing it into my mouth.”

“That’s right. You did it to survive. Why can’t you remember that you were once weak too?”

Jangcheon’s lips twisted.

“Wangpal. Hong Sochil. So U-pyeong.”

“…?”

“Three of the fifteen who tried to take my dumpling. Unfortunately, the others were already dead.”

Three names fell from his Disciple’s lips.

Their meaning was unmistakable. Those three no longer belonged to this world. And until the moment they breathed their last, they must have suffered unimaginable pain.

“They didn’t remember me, but I never forgot them for a single day. More than ten years ago, as I chewed that dirt-covered dumpling, I realized something. *So this is the world. The weak are trampled, and the strong do the trampling. Then I must become strong. I must enjoy the rights of the strong.*”

As Jangcheon recited the vow he had made that day in a chilling voice, Jeok Cheongang finally understood.

“You… You…”

“Yes. I never changed. Not once, from the day I first met you until now.”

His white teeth gleamed in the darkness. Jangcheon giggled.

“It was thrilling. At first, they begged me to spare them. Later, they screamed at me to kill them. But once they finally fell silent, I felt empty inside. Drinking myself senseless at a pleasure house and embracing a woman couldn’t make the feeling go away.”

He could only have been a born Slaughter Saint.

Only murder could fill that emptiness. Jangcheon would likely go on killing until the moment he drew his final breath.

“The timing was perfect. You happened to be so absorbed in your training that you neglected me, which allowed me to run wild to my heart’s content.”

Jeok Cheongang wanted to cover his ears. He wanted to cover his ears, close his eyes, and erase the memory of that day, which had been branded into his mind.

His body trembled with rage and betrayal toward the Disciple he had raised as his own kin.

But what tormented him most was the affection he still felt for that Disciple.

“Of course, I wasn’t entirely at ease either. Was it four months ago? I came back after taking care of some business and found you waiting for me. The moment I saw you acting unlike yourself, I knew I’d been found out.”

“Stop.”

“You trusted me far too completely to start following me for no reason, so someone must have tipped you off… Ah, it must have been the Namgung Family.”

“I said shut up!”

A tremendous wave of qi tore through the alley.

Confronted with a fury he had never before seen from his Master, Jangcheon’s eyes widened.

“Master?”

“You bastard! How dare you call me Master with that mouth? Do you still not understand what you’ve done?”

“Why are you acting like this? Surely you don’t intend to cast aside your only Disciple over something so trivial?”

“Trivial? Did you call this trivial?”

“Master, you’re like a father to me. I believed that even if everyone under heaven condemned my faults, you would understand. Because you’re my father.”

Father.

The word Jeok Cheongang had wanted so desperately to hear.

He gritted his teeth.

“You’re wrong.”

“Wrong?”

Jangcheon smiled faintly.

“Then why don’t you strike me dead right now? You had countless chances, both now and throughout the past four months.”

“That’s—”

“Am I wrong?”

Jeok Cheongang could not answer. Everything Jangcheon had said was true. He had deliberately looked away from the truth and tried to justify doing so.

Because no matter what it took, he had wanted to believe in his Disciple.

A long time passed before he finally spoke.

“I’ll sever your Sinews and Meridians.”

“My Sinews and Meridians. And then?”

“I’ll cripple your dantian. You’ll spend the rest of your life repenting for your crimes.”

“Facing a wall in meditation until the day I die. The very thought is horrifying.”

Despite his words, Jangcheon’s face was full of laughter.

“But did our sect’s rules change while this useless Disciple wasn’t looking? As I understand it, a case like this calls for immediate execution, no questions asked.”

“…This is my final act of mercy. Put that man down and step away at once.”

Jangcheon blinked as if he had forgotten something important.

The middle-aged man in his arms, his entire body drenched in blood, was still drawing ragged breaths.

“Ah, right. I’d forgotten about him.”

Slash.

Blood erupted in a fountain.

Jeok Cheongang stared at it with trembling eyes.

Jangcheon’s hand had moved without the slightest hesitation. The man’s throat had been cut. His body convulsed, then fell still.

“Is this your answer?”

“It’s already too late. Even if I saved him, he would spend the rest of his life crippled. Wouldn’t it be better to give him a clean death?”

“You… You’re no longer the child I knew.”

“I am exactly the child you knew, Master. You simply misunderstood me from the very beginning.”

“Enough. Your evil deeds end today.”

“Do you truly intend to cripple me and make me spend the rest of my life facing a wall?”

A faint fear showed on his Disciple’s face.

Jeok Cheongang clenched his fist until blood seeped from his palm. One move. A single move was all it would take to erase Jangcheon from this world.

But he knew he could not bring himself to do it.

Severing his Disciple’s Sinews and Meridians, crippling his martial arts, and imprisoning him was the best he could do.

“Do you regret it?”

“Regret?”

“Yes. Regret.”

It would change nothing, but Jeok Cheongang wanted to hear the answer from Jangcheon’s own lips.

Then, in the next instant, every trace of fear vanished from Jangcheon’s face.

“I was relieved.”

“What?”

“I couldn’t see or hear you, but I knew you had been watching me for the past four months. Why else do you think I did this right in front of you?”

Jangcheon’s face was reflected in Jeok Cheongang’s vacant eyes. He continued with perfect composure.

“You can’t kill me, Master. It wouldn’t matter if I killed not dozens but hundreds. Before I left, I wanted to confirm that one last time.”

“Before you leave? What do you mean?”

“There may be fathers who blame their children for their faults, but there is no father anywhere in this world who kills his own child with his own hands.”

“…!”

“Thank you, Master. Thank you for raising me as your child rather than merely your Disciple. Thank you for trying to save a child like me until the very end. Thanks to you, my one path to survival has opened.”

Jeok Cheongang stood frozen as if his breath had stopped. Before him, Jangcheon gave a deep bow filled with genuine sincerity.

When he raised his head again, a small white porcelain vial was held between his lips.

“It’s Bone-Melting Powder.”

Bone-Melting Powder was a deadly poison that dissolved flesh and bone.

Even a tiny amount would be fatal if the vial shattered inside his mouth. Not even a celestial immortal could save him.

Jeok Cheongang roared in fury.

“Jangcheon! You bastard!”

“That bow I just gave you… was my final farewell. I’m leaving now. I’ll go far away and never return.”

“You think I’ll let you leave like this?”

“Then kill me. That’s the only way.”

“…!”

“Kill me.”

Kill me.

Those were his Disciple’s final words.

Jeok Cheongang blinked. The ceiling had looked blurry for some time, and now something was running down his cheek.

“The inn is old. Rain must be leaking through.”

It was a winter night, one day before New Year’s Day.[995]

[995] Here, New Year’s Day is the first day of the traditional lunar calendar.

Chapter 178

“The inn is old. Rain’s leaking in.”

I stared up at the blameless ceiling.

“It is a little run-down.”

Of course, no rain was falling. The ink-dark sky was perfectly still.

It wasn’t the inn that was old, but Jeok Cheongang’s heart. Remembering the painful events of long ago had sprung a leak in his eyes.

I thought the old man had neither blood nor tears in him.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

I had never imagined that this irascible Supreme Peak master had a past like this. I also had to revise my assessment of Jopil, whom I had dismissed as merely insane.

He was even crazier than I thought.

He had thoroughly used and discarded the Master who had saved him from the brink of death. From what I’d heard, he clearly hadn’t felt a shred of guilt, even at the very end.

I was shocked that anyone could be filled with such pure malice—and relieved that Jopil no longer existed in this world.

“But he still managed to escape alive. The Namgung Family must have been keeping a close eye on him.”

The Namgung Family—a staple of martial arts novels.

They were one of the Five Great Families, an organization said to rival the Nine Sects and One Gang. I might not know the details, but hunting down and killing a single fugitive should have been nothing to them.

Unless someone had helped him.

“Could it be…?”

At my question, Jeok Cheongang calmly nodded.

“I went to the Azure Sky Sword King and asked for his help. It was the last duty I could perform.”

The Disciple had abandoned his Master and left, yet the Master had protected him to the very end.

The more I heard, the more unbelievable their Master-Disciple relationship became.

“…That’s incredible.”

“Incredible? I raised a Slaughter Saint like him as my Disciple, then let him loose upon the world because I was blinded by personal affection. It was a foolish choice.”

Jeok Cheongang continued with a self-deprecating laugh.

"The Azure Sky Sword King told me the same thing. He said I would regret it. He was right. Every moment of the past ten years has been filled with regret."

"If you could go back to that day, what would you do?"

His answer came without hesitation.

"I would save him. And I would regret it all over again. Even if I were given a hundred chances, the man I was then would make the same choice every time."

The me back then would have done the same?

That was a loaded choice of words. It also meant that the Jeok Cheongang of today was different.

Could it be…?

Perhaps those ten years had been his time to prepare.

To prepare himself to personally kill the Disciple who might still be committing atrocities somewhere in the world.

If that was the case…

A thought flashed through my mind, and I asked carefully—very carefully.

"Um…"

"Speak."

Jeok Cheongang's voice was low. His fathomless gaze seemed to see through everything, and my heart began to pound.

I swallowed, then opened my mouth.

"I believe there's something you want to ask me."

We hadn't sat down face-to-face just to reminisce about the past.

He had questions for me, and I had questions for him.

We each had things to ask and answers to give. And I wasn't the one holding the sword hilt.

"I'll answer you. Whatever you ask."

"…"

Jeok Cheongang, the one holding the sword hilt, silently ran his fingers over his empty wineglass.

The silence seemed as though it might never end. Fifteen minutes? Half an hour? Half a shichen[996]? I had no idea how much time passed.

A cold wind howled outside, but whether from tension or something else, my entire body was drenched in sweat.

At last, the long silence broke.

"…Is he dead?"

His voice was terribly hoarse. He was trying to sound calm, but the question held a jumble of emotions.

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[996] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

When I nodded, the old man's gray eyes trembled.

"I see. So that's how it ended."

Jeok Cheongang unconsciously tried to tip back his wineglass, then noticed that it was empty and gave a hollow laugh.

"I suspected as much. I sensed traces of our sect in you."

It was because of the internal energy I had gained from the Blazing Flame Divine Pill. Just as his internal energy had led me to suspect that he was the Fire King, mine had told him the same thing.

"Did he die peacefully?"

"That…"

I pictured Jopil thrashing as blood streamed from his seven apertures.

After drawing on even his innate qi, he had fought me to the death and died with half his upper body blown away.

When I hesitated, Jeok Cheongang waved a wrinkled hand.

"Enough. It was my fault for asking a pointless question. What peaceful death is there in a battle between martial artists?"

"His suffering would have been brief."

"A man who spent his life inflicting pain on countless others received a better death than he deserved."

Despite his words, his expression was bitter.

If Jeok Cheongang had found Jopil, he would have used the finest move at his disposal.

He would have granted him the swiftest, most painless death possible.

Maybe that was why he returned to the world.

But Jeok Cheongang had failed to achieve his goal. Jopil had encountered me before his former Master could reach him, and lost his life.

How would Jeok Cheongang react—

"I owe you a debt."

"Pardon?"

"Did you not hear me? I said I owe you."

"No, I heard you. It's just…"

I was dumbfounded.

Never in my wildest dreams had I expected those words to come from him so easily.

As I blinked at him, wondering what on earth was happening, Jeok Cheongang continued.

"Someone had to stop that child. You did in my stead what I should have done ten years ago. And…"

Jeok Cheongang's lips suddenly twitched, as though he had never said anything like this to anyone before.

After a brief hesitation, he finally spoke.

"I'm sorry. I sincerely apologize to all of you for acting so rashly before."

My voice burst out before I could stop it.

"Whoa."

"Whoa?"

"Ah, it's nothing. I was so surprised that it just slipped out."

"Is it truly so astonishing for this old man to apologize?"

It seemed plenty astonishing to me. Besides, he'd looked incredibly uncomfortable saying it, so what was he complaining about?

"…Well, you see…"

I trailed off awkwardly, then saw Jeok Cheongang's face beginning to contort and quickly changed my tune.

"The renowned Fire King, Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, personally apologizing to a junior as young as me! I can only bow before your magnanimity and humility."

"…"

"…"

Just look at his face. Jekyll and Hyde were fighting it out right there.

Every muscle in Jeok Cheongang's face conveyed his fierce inner struggle over whether or not to hit me. Eventually, he sighed.

"I cannot make heads or tails of you. You may leave now."

"Yes, sir."

"And take those children with you."

Cheongpung was fast asleep with his forehead pressed against the table, while Hyuk Mujin was still sprawled facedown in the courtyard.

Before Jeok Cheongang could change his mind, I quickly gathered up the two deadweights and headed for the second floor. Then I remembered something.

Oh, right. I have to return the Flame Divine Palm martial arts manual and the sword.

I had already swallowed the Blazing Flame Divine Pill, so there was nothing I could do about that, but I still needed to return the other items.

I desperately wanted to settle everything between Jeok Cheongang and me once and for all today.

"Um, Sir Jeok. I'm sorry, but there's one more thing I need to tell you…"

I turned back, my voice as tiny as an ant, then stopped short.

Glug, glug.

Left alone, Jeok Cheongang was pouring drinks.

One glass, then another. He placed the second wineglass before the empty seat across from him and began drinking in silence.

I watched him for a moment, then suddenly thought:

He looks small.

The back of the giant known as the Fire King looked small and lonely.

I quietly turned away and climbed the stairs.

Once the presence behind him had disappeared, Jeok Cheongang muttered,

“You deserved to die.”

Jangcheon had killed dozens in Anhui alone. There was no telling how many people had fallen victim to his Disciple over the past ten years.

“You called it Might Makes Right, didn’t you? You’re the same. In the end, you died at the hands of someone stronger than you.”

No one remained strong forever, just as no one remained weak forever.

Even Jeok Cheongang, a Supreme Peak master, was weaker than someone.

Yet some people forgot that fact. Drunk on their own strength—or on blood—they strayed down the wrong path.

“What a pathetic fool.”

Jeok Cheongang drained his drink. His Disciple’s words from that day long ago seemed to echo in his ears.

I have never changed. Not once, from the day I first met you until now.

Over the past ten years, he had turned those words over in his mind countless times. That single sentence had lodged near his heart like a dagger and tormented him.

“Did you truly never change? Not even once?”

They had spent many years together. At times, Jeok Cheongang had been a strict teacher; at others, he had cared for his Disciple like a loving father.

No—he had believed that was what he had been.

But it had all been an illusion. If it had truly been otherwise, Jangcheon would have chosen a very different path.

“How could rice paper be black from the beginning?”

Being born into this world was like receiving a blank sheet of rice paper.

A person passed through countless moments between birth and death.

When death finally arrived, those moments came together to complete a single painting. The painting Jangcheon had created was… entirely ink-black.

Jeok Cheongang had watched it from the closest distance, yet he hadn’t known.

“Cheon.”

The old man stared at the seat across from him, where a wineglass had been set. One by one, phantomlike figures appeared in the empty chair.

A child hunched over as he stuffed dumplings into his mouth. A boy clutching the wooden sword his Master had made for him, his cheeks flushed bright red.

His limbs lengthened, and his gaze sharpened. Before long, a tall young man stood glaring at the old man.

Kill me.

That day, Jeok Cheongang had been unable to answer his Disciple's cutting words.

But if he ever met his Disciple again, there was something he had desperately wanted to say.

"I'm sorry. I'm so sorry."

Whoooosh.

A cold wind slipped through the door of the old inn and brushed across the wineglass.

"Benefactor!"

I awoke to a terrible racket. Cheongpung, practically bursting with excitement, was bouncing up and down.

"This is my pavilion, so why… Ah."

Right. This wasn't the Jin Family of Taiyuan. It was an inn.

At the same time, the events of the previous day flashed through my mind like a panorama. It wouldn't have been an exaggeration to say I had crossed the boundary between life and death.

Well, that aside—

"Stop jumping around. There's enough dust in here already."

"I'm allowed to jump today!"

How was anyone supposed to sleep through this?

Hyuk Mujin, who had been curled up like a shrimp in one corner of the floor, blearily opened his eyes.

"Is this… paradise?"

That bastard started talking nonsense the moment he woke up.

It was absurd, but then I remembered that yesterday, after trying to escape on his own, he had been knocked unconscious by a duck bone Jeok Cheongang flicked at him.

"You awake?"

"Captain?"

Hyuk Mujin's eyes widened when he saw me. Then he sighed.

“So this isn’t paradise.”

“…What the hell is that supposed to mean, you bastard?”

“It was a joke. A joke. I’m just glad to see you alive again.”

“Says the guy who tried to run away on his own.”

“Come on. Why do you have to put it like that?”

Grinning shamelessly, Hyuk Mujin looked around. More precisely, he looked at Cheongpung, who was running laps around the room like a train.

“What’s all this commotion so early in the morning? What good thing happened to make him run around like that?”

“No idea. He says he’s allowed to jump today.”

“He must’ve eaten something tasty.”

“…”

It was obviously bullshit, but since we were talking about Cheongpung, its credibility skyrocketed.

Giving him a doubtful look, I asked Cheongpung,

“What day is it today?”

Cheongpung, who had been circling the room and driving me crazy, stopped dead.

“Benefactor, you don’t even know that?”

“…Let’s refrain from saying things like that. It hits ten times harder coming from you.”

“It’s the first day of the new year. New Year’s Day!”

Hyuk Mujin and I nodded at the same time.

“Ah, so it’s New Year’s Day.”

“Right. It’s already New Year’s Day.”

“I thought it was something els—”

“Yeah. A whole year has already pass—”

After a brief silence, a profound realization struck us.

Ah. The Jin Family of Taiyuan.

At that moment, Wipeng’s threat from before I left the family rang vividly in my ears.

Chapter 179

It really was New Year's Day.

It had only been two days since Wipeng had given me strict instructions before I left the Jin Family of Taiyuan, yet I had completely forgotten.

Hyuk Mujin swallowed a hollow breath and spoke.

"W-What do we do?"

"What do you mean, what do we do? Even if we'd remembered, we wouldn't have made it back in time."

This was the Fire King we were talking about.

Considering the mood yesterday, if I'd told him I had family business and needed to leave, he would have sent me off with a hearty laugh.

Straight down the road to the underworld, of course.

"Great Hero Wipeng is going to kill me."

I patted the ashen-faced Hyuk Mujin on the shoulder.

"Don't worry. He can't kill me."

"Oh, me neither!"

"…"

Such was the sorrow of having no powerful backer.

Still, I had no intention of deliberately dragging my feet.

Today was the day the Jin Family of Taiyuan would rise as the undisputed ruler of Shanxi Province. The youngest son of the family couldn't afford to be late.

"Pack your things. We're leaving right now."

Not that I had much to pack. One travel bundle was everything I owned.

We were ready in no time and headed downstairs. The inn had been decked out in red for New Year's Day, and despite the early hour, it was bustling with people.

Two men stood out among the crowd.

"Oh, you're up?"

"Tsk, tsk. Young fellows shouldn't sleep so much."

"Exactly. When I was young, there were plenty of days when I couldn't even get one shichen[997] of sleep."

"One whole shichen[998]? Why, back in my day…"

The two old men raised their hands in greeting, then went right back to passing wine cups between themselves.

Their flushed faces and the wine jar beside them showed they had already been drinking heavily this early in the day.

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[997] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[998] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Hyuk Mujin, following behind me, whispered in a small voice,

“What kind of combination is that?”

“No idea.”

One was a giant of an old man, larger than most strapping young men. The other was so small and frail that a stiff breeze might have carried him away.

The Fire King was one thing.

But when did Jang Taebo get here?

Had he come because of the commission?

In any case, the two old men—each a master in his own field—seemed to have grown quite close.

“It’s pretty chaotic in here. Can’t we just slip out?”

“Slip out, my ass. Don’t you remember getting knocked unconscious with a duck bone yesterday?”

“That was a duck bone? Damn, no wonder my skull was ringing.”

“If we pretend nothing happened and leave, he’ll crack it open.”

“I’d rather avoid that.”

“So? Want to make a run for it?”

Hyuk Mujin sighed gloomily.

“Phew. What a rotten way to start the new year.”

I couldn’t have agreed more. No one in the world would want to run into Fire King Jeok Cheongang first thing on New Year’s Day.

“Grandpas, do you have any dumplings?”

“There’s plenty of meat, too. Eat up.”

“Yaaay!”

…Except that guy.

Hyuk Mujin and I trudged forward with heavy hearts, like oxen being led to the slaughterhouse.

Cheongpung, who was shoveling food into his mouth at the speed of light, beamed and held out several plates.

“Hewe! It’s delishush! Try shome!”

“…You eat plenty.”

“Thanksh, I will!”

Someone like him was a Peak master. The sheer unfairness of reality filled me with despair for the future of the Murim.

Jang Taebo spoke up.

“So, what are you all planning to do now?”

“We’re going back to our family first. We have some business to take care of.”

“Ah, I see. You said there was going to be a gathering at the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

At present, every move the Jin Family of Taiyuan made was a hot topic throughout Shanxi Province.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan, once treated as an old tiger past its prime, had reclaimed the throne of Shanxi Murim after many years. It was only natural that the interest and expectations surrounding them were extraordinary.

Even Jang Taebo, a homebody living in a tiny place like Jang Family Village, had heard about it.

“That’s all anyone talks about whenever people gather these days. Even ordinary people with nothing to do with the Murim are flocking there for the spectacle. That tells you everything.”

“Will that many people really come?”

“A grand feast always draws all sorts of hangers-on. Shanxi Province may be a frontier region, but this is about becoming the hegemon of an entire province. I may not be a martial artist, but I’ve seen and heard enough in my time. Just wait and see. Ah, and…”

Jang Taebo lowered his voice.

“Don’t worry about the commission.”

The commission.

His words suddenly reminded me of something I hadn’t had the chance to ask before.

“By the way, is there anything else you need?”

“What do you mean?”

“Well, there must be something.”

Even the neighborhood laundromat charged a fee for repairs. Jang Taebo was a master artisan renowned throughout the world. He might not have been as skilled as he was in his prime, but I didn’t believe his abilities had vanished over the past ten years.

His work had to command an appropriate price…

Realizing what I meant, Jang Taebo stroked his white beard.

“You mean you want to compensate me?”

“To be honest, I can’t give you as much as you might be expecting.”

“Then just give me ten thousand nyang.”

Ten thousand nyang was a hundred silver nyang. It was certainly an enormous sum, but considering his fame, it felt like nothing more than a special discount.

I nodded readily. It wasn’t my money, anyway.

“I’ll prepare it and send it to your home.”

“Ten thousand silver nyang? You’d have to tear out every last pillar holding up the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“…Ten thousand *silver* nyang?”

"Of course. Did my worth look that cheap to you?"

"That's a whopping million nyang."

"Not a whopping million. A mere million. You'll be getting the greatest divine weapon under heaven. What does a little money matter?"

"…"

Of course it mattered.

How much would a million nyang be worth in the real world? Hundreds of billions of won[999]? Trillions[1000]?

Jang Taebo let out a quiet laugh at my expression.

"I don't need it."

"I'm sorry, but would you consider a quick deal for ten thousand nyang—pardon?"

"I said I don't need it. What would I do with that much money? I couldn't spend it all before I died. Having an opportunity like this come my way while I'm still alive is payment enough."

Was this the spirit of a true artisan?

What a shining example, this Jang Taebo. Every blacksmith under heaven should follow his example and Taebo accordingly.

As I trembled with emotion, Hyuk Mujin cut in with an admiring look.

"Then why don't you take the ten thousand nyang for now and give it to me?"

That bastard could write an autobiography. He could call it *A Hundred Ways to Get Yourself Beaten to Death*.

I smacked him on the back of the head, then bowed politely to Jang Taebo.

"Then I'll leave it in your hands."

"I'm the one who should be asking a favor. I can't promise how long it will take, but I'll create something that will make the world tremble. Until then, make sure you acquire the strength and qualifications worthy of wielding it."

"I'll do my best."

"Good. Then that settles it. I'll have to place my trust in you."

Jang Taebo nodded, then paused.

"Ah. Could I ask one more favor?"

"…?"

"Build my house again. It all burned down, and I don't even have anywhere to sleep."

The home he had bought after retiring—the precious place where he had spent his golden years in peace—had vanished overnight.

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[999] Hundreds of billions of won—roughly 100 billion to under one trillion won—would be about $71 million–$710 million, or €65 million–€650 million.

[1000] Trillions of won—roughly one trillion to under ten trillion won—would be about $710 million–$7.1 billion, or €650 million–€6.5 billion.

At the sorrow in Jang Taebo's voice, my gaze drifted to the side of its own accord.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been quietly sipping his wine while we talked, looked up.

"What are you staring at?"

There was no trace of the emotional, solemn Jeok Cheongang from last night. I subtly averted my gaze.

"…Nothing."

"If you have something to say, say it. This old man isn't so petty."

"Are you really sure?"

"Go ahead."

The moment he finished speaking, the space beneath the table began to heat up.

It wasn't as though the innkeeper were a modern man who had brought in an electric heater…

Fuck. Flame Divine Palm.

Tears welled in my eyes as I answered.

"I was just thinking that you looked a good ten years younger than usual today."

Jeok Cheongang frowned.

"What? Ten years?"

Damn it. Subtracting ten from a hundred still left ninety.

I hurriedly revised my answer.

"Twenty years…"

"Twenty years?"

"Thirty years…"

In the space of barely three seconds, Jeok Cheongang had grown thirty years younger. He nodded in satisfaction.

"I thought you were a fellow with nothing but shit in your head, but you do have some fairly plausible thoughts after all."

"…"

Hyuk Mujin looked like he had something to say, but he clamped his mouth shut.

Apparently, he had no desire to make *A Hundred Ways to Get Yourself Beaten to Death* his final work.

Instead, he kept poking me in the side, looking desperate to leave this place immediately.

Of course, I feel the same way.

But before we could go, there was one last thing I needed to settle.

I spoke in the most respectful tone I could manage.

"I have several items in my possession."

Jeok Cheongang, his face flushed as he tipped back his wine cup, let out a quiet laugh.

“Were you ever planning to return them?”

“Of course I did.”

“That’s right. If you don’t return them, you’ll see something ugly.”

“…”

The old man could see straight through people’s hearts like a ghost.

I forced a smile and placed the items I had already taken out on the table.

The Flame Divine Palm martial arts manual I had obtained from Jopil, and the Unnamed Sword made from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

“As you already know, Great Hero Jeok, the Blazing Flame Divine Pill…”

“You gobbled it up.”

“Yes. That’s right.”

“But…”

A wrinkled finger tapped against the table. Jeok Cheongang continued in a dry voice.

“Where is the Treasured Jade?”

“Pardon?”

“The treasured jade. The jade.”

Treasured jade? As in some sort of treasure or gemstone?

Jeok Cheongang didn’t seem like the type to obsess over ordinary jewelry, so it had to be extremely important.

But since I hadn’t even known it existed, I could only stare at him in bewilderment.

“These are the only things I received.”

“Received? You didn’t collect them yourself?”

“No. There were circumstances. They were handed to me right after I woke up.”

“Do you suspect any of the people involved?”

Gong Yacheong and Socheon had handed Jopil’s belongings over to me. Neither of them was the sort to quietly pocket something behind everyone else’s back.

The same went for the members of the reconnaissance squad who had been there. I didn’t know what had happened, but that didn’t change my trust in them.

“They wouldn’t have. No, absolutely not.”

Jeok Cheongang studied me for a moment before speaking.

“Then it must be one of two things. Someone deceived you, or that child lost it.”

“…”

“What a nuisance. This has become troublesome.”

Jeok Cheongang had likely returned to the world not only to find his Disciple, but also to recover the Fire Gate Clan's treasures that had been scattered because of him.

The Treasured Jade seemed to be one of them.

It was a treasure that even the Fire King was willing to endure the trouble of searching for at all costs.

Damn it. I never even got to see it.

Just as a creeping sense of danger began to outweigh my curiosity about what the jade actually was, Jeok Cheongang spoke.

"It can't be helped. Keep them for now."

That casual remark brought my thoughts to a complete halt.

Wait. Did he mean…

"You want me to keep these?"

"Yes."

"Both of them?"

"All three. Have you forgotten the one in your stomach? Anything that originated from our sect must be reclaimed, one way or another."

"…!"

"I'm joking."

"Phew."

"Tsk, tsk. You're still young, but your nerve is already the size of a bean."

Bean or cannonball, I didn't care.

I wanted nothing more to do with that terrifying old man. Ever.

I took a deep breath and opened my mouth.

"I'm sorry, but I'll have to decline—"

"If you refuse, I'll reclaim them right now. All three."

"…"

"This time, I'm serious."

Once again, the space beneath the table grew scorching hot. It was Flame Divine Palm, of course.

What the fuck?

I was trying to return the items to their rightful owner. And I couldn't even do that?

Overcome with resentment and indignation, I demanded, "Why are you doing this to me?"

"Do you expect an old man like me to carry those cumbersome things around? I don't have the strength for that."

"What if someone takes them from me?"

“Then this old man will kill you.”

“What if I learn the martial art?”

“Then you’ll die even more painfully.”

What kind of bullshit situation was this?

Leaving me standing there in a daze, the Fire King rose from his seat.

Cheongpung, who was still cramming food into his mouth, looked up.

“Gwandpa, awe you leaving?”

“…You’re even worse than your grandfather. Slow down.”

After exchanging a silent glance of farewell with Jang Taebo, Jeok Cheongang turned away and tossed out one meaningful remark.

“Let’s meet again soon.”

I didn’t want to see him.

Ever.

Chapter 180

New Year's Day.

Jin Wikyung's reaction upon seeing the sunlight on the first day of the new year was short and simple.

"Fantastic."

Wolhwa, who had been tilting her teacup with graceful composure, let out a quiet laugh. She had arrived at the Jin Family of Taiyuan the previous night.

With the family currently barring all outsiders from entering, admitting her was a show of respect for their alliance.

"Are you really that happy?"

"How could I not be?"

"I suppose you have every reason to be, considering everything that's happened. Two years ago, I never imagined a day like this would come."

"That hurts to hear."

Wolhwa covered her mouth in exaggerated dismay.

"My goodness, shouldn't I be the one saying that? We've been waiting for you for so long."

"I'll keep my promise. Without fail."

"I hope so. It would be troublesome if you went back on your word a second time."

"Let's stop. I'm tired."

"That makes two of us."

The previous night had been a long one. After an intense back-and-forth, they had finally found common ground that gave each of them what they wanted.

Both sides needed the other's help if they wished to wield influence in Shanxi Murim.

Having finally obtained what she wanted, Wolhwa gave him a prim smile.

"Still, we did give you a valuable piece of information, didn't we?"

Jin Wikyung replied with a disgruntled look.

"Oh, that information? I heard our family's Datong Branch played some part in the matter as well."

"We were the first to bring you the information. We were also the ones who promptly sent a messenger eagle."

"That much… I'll admit."

Wolhwa suddenly narrowed her eyes.

"But aren't you worried?"

"About what?"

"The Heavenly Wind Band."

The news that the Heavenly Wind Band, which had been prowling around Datong, had been annihilated was certainly welcome. But it was also profoundly shocking.

One person had single-handedly wiped out hundreds of mounted bandits, including a Peak master? Unless that person was a Supreme Peak master, it would have been nearly impossible.

Wolhwa ran one long finger along her teacup.

“Who do you think it was?”

“Who knows? We’ll have to find out in time.”

Jin Wikyung suppressed a laugh. The world might be vast and full of reclusive eccentrics, but Supreme Peak masters were anything but common.

When he had first heard the news about the Heavenly Wind Band, only one name had flashed through his mind.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

It was most likely him.

Considering the relationship they had built over the years, he ought to tell Wolhwa. But the matter was far too significant to share even with the Chief Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect.

“Don’t worry too much. Our family is keeping a close eye on the situation.”

“For someone saying that, you look awfully relaxed.”

“How could I be relaxed? I merely assume that whoever annihilated the notoriously vicious Heavenly Wind Band wasn’t a master of demonic, heterodox arts.”

Wolhwa narrowed her eyes at his feigned ignorance.

But she couldn’t press him any further. If the Jin Family of Taiyuan had truly possessed ties to a Supreme Peak master, its rise to its current position would have been far easier.

“Well, in any case, you have my sincere congratulations.”

“Thank you.”

“But someone else has been awfully quiet.”

Knowing exactly whom Wolhwa meant, Jin Wikyung shook his head.

“He’s been dissatisfied since birth.”

A prickly voice asked,

“Are you talking about me?”

“Who else would I be talking about?”

Wipeng, who had been leaning diagonally against the wall of the office, opened his mouth.

“I wholeheartedly agree with my lord. It truly is a fantastic day.”

“What’s gotten into you? Whenever I say something like that, you lecture me about dignity and propriety.”

“What else am I supposed to call a fantastic day?”

His subordinate, usually as strict and fussy as an old schoolmaster, was humoring him for once. Jin Wikyung smiled in satisfaction.

“Exactly. That’s how important this occasion will be.”

“Can you hear the murmuring from far away? I hear that not only the influential martial artists of Shanxi Murim, but even commoners who heard the news have come.”

“Oh, is that true?”

“Indeed. We’ve also received a letter of congratulations from the Heavenly Sword True Person, the Sect Leader of Huashan.”

“Oh!”

“The Three Plum Blossom Elites should be arriving soon as well.”

Jin Wikyung already knew all of this, but it still felt good to hear it again.

The Nine Sects and One Gang were pillars of the Murim world, and their influence was immense. Even if only part of that great alliance was represented, it was practically equivalent to the entire orthodox faction vouching for the legitimacy of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Of course, he couldn’t deny that the Sword Saint and Cheongpung had played a significant role in that.

“And that’s not all. Isn’t Prince Shangshan, a descendant of the Son of Heaven, coming as well? This means that both the government and the Murim have acknowledged our family as the undisputed hegemon of Shanxi Province.”

“Of course! Absolutely!”

As Jin Wikyung’s spirits soared, Wipeng smiled.

“Do you know what the even better news is?”

“You’re really going all out today. What is it? Tell me already!”

The next moment, the smile at the corners of Wipeng’s mouth vanished without a trace.

“At this gathering, where countless martial artists and commoners, distinguished guests from the Nine Sects and One Gang, and even a descendant of the imperial family are coming, both Young Masters are absent.”

“…Ah.”

“I can at least understand the Second Young Master. Enlightenment doesn’t come whenever one wants it to, so secluded training is understandable. I’m a martial artist too. But!”

Wipeng continued with a fierce glare.

“The Third Young Master absolutely cannot be let off the hook. Leaving at a time like this as though none of it concerned him was bad enough, but now all word from him has stopped completely.”

Jin Wikyung quietly averted his gaze. Wolhwa, his only lifeline, merely shrugged as if she knew nothing and watched the spectacle unfold.

“He’ll come.”

“What do you mean, he’ll come? He left last year saying he’d be right back.”

Jin Wikyung opened his mouth to object, then stopped. The way Wipeng phrased it sounded strange, but it wasn’t wrong.

Wipeng ground his teeth and continued.

“Going off to make a weapon when we’re facing such a momentous occasion… I’m an idiot for trusting the Third Young Master even for a moment.”

“Now, now.”

“Am I wrong?”

“Now, hold on!”

“Why? What about it?”

Jin Wikyung flinched at Wipeng’s bulging eyes. Then salvation arrived in the form of a voice from outside the office.

“Lesser Family Head, the preparations are complete.”

“…There you have it.”

Wipeng’s lips moved as though he still had more to say, but he released a deep sigh instead. This was hardly the first time something like this had happened. They had to deal with the business at hand first.

“This time, you must give the Third Young Master a proper talking-to.”

“Of course I will.”

Jin Wikyung grinned and left the office.

Fifty martial artists radiating sharp auras stood in formation before the pavilion. Every one of them was at least a First Rate master, and they stared at their lord with unwavering composure.

An eight-cheok[1001]-tall giant, Jin Wikyung was the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. In place of the absent Family Head, he had led the family for the past two years and finally set it upon a firm foundation.

His tightly closed lips parted.

“Let’s go.”

Wipeng, Wolhwa, and the fifty martial artists followed him. As they crossed the quiet grounds of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, their numbers continued to swell.

Fifty became a hundred, a hundred became two hundred, and two hundred became three hundred…

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had suffered as though its limbs had been torn away in the previous war, but its recovery had been swift, and its growth even swifter.

[1001] A cheok is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Eight cheok is about 2.42 m (7 ft 11 in).

Our family has grown stronger.

The One Pavilion, Two Halls, and Three Teams advancing alongside him were proof of that.

They were the arms, legs, waist, and torso of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, stronger and sturdier than ever before.

Remembering the countless sacrifices and efforts that had brought them to this day, Jin Wikyung felt a surge of emotion.

“Lesser Family Head.”

Before he knew it, they had reached the Gate Guard Pavilion.

The gate guards standing watch at the main entrance bowed with crisp, disciplined movements. Beyond the solid stone walls, the cheers of countless people rang out.

“Wow, this really is fantastic.”

“My lord, give the order.”

Wolhwa smiled brightly, while Wipeng wore a more solemn expression than ever.

Jin Wikyung took in their faces and drew a deep breath. The next moment, his dignified voice rang out.

“Open the gates.”

It marked the beginning of the grand banquet that would continue for the next three days—and served as the signal flare announcing that the Jin Family of Taiyuan had become the hegemon of Shanxi Murim.

The area in front of the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s gates was packed with people. There were martial artists wearing swords and blades, merchants hoping to seize an opportunity, and commoners who belonged to neither group.

Even though it was broad daylight, firecrackers celebrating the first day of the new year went off now and then.

Boom! Boom-boom!

“Waaaaah!”

While hundreds upon hundreds of people laughed and chatted in the festive atmosphere, a handful wore faces fit for a funeral.

“Damn it.”

“What kind of situation is this?”

“I ought to just—”

The five middle-aged men—the heads of the five sects collectively known as the Five Gates of Shanxi—couldn’t smooth out their crumpled expressions.

Of the five, Woo Hwangtae, chief of the Seongun Escort Bureau, was in the worst state by far, frantic with worry thanks to his worthless son.

They wouldn't even grant me an audience.

He had arrived five days earlier and requested a meeting countless times.

He had come to clean up the mess caused by his son, Woo Jintae.

But the carefully prepared letters and gifts he sent had been turned away without ever crossing the Jin Family of Taiyuan's threshold. His pride had taken a beating, but in the end, he had resorted to coming in person.

"I am Woo of the Seongun Escort Bureau."

The Seongun Escort Bureau had endured for three generations, and everyone in Shanxi Province knew its name. After all, it had flaunted the enormous fortune it had amassed through any means necessary.

Yet the gate guard's response had been indifferent.

"You can't meet him right now."

"Come now, man. What do you mean? I'm telling you, I'm the chief of the Seongun Escort Bureau!"

"Whether you're a bureau chief or a sect leader, I don't know or care. I follow orders."

…!

Had he ever suffered such humiliation in his life?

Like Woo Jintae, he had spent his entire life enjoying every advantage his family's prestige afforded him. He had suffered a few setbacks and had occasionally been ignored by those of higher status, but he could endure that much.

But to be treated this way by a mere gate guard!

Every time Woo Hwangtae thought about it, the back of his head throbbed.

Those fucking bastards. No matter how powerful they are, how dare they treat someone like this?

Even his son, who had a child of his own, had returned so badly beaten that it was difficult to tell whether he was still human or some blue-skinned beast.

Father and son had both been utterly humiliated. It was too embarrassing to complain to the other sect leaders.

"Huff… Hooo…"

As Woo Hwangtae exhaled through his flushed face, the other heads of the Five Gates of Shanxi watched him cautiously.

"Chief Woo, are you all right?"

"If you're feeling unwell, perhaps we should come back tomorrow…"

Woo Hwangtae snapped at them.

"Would you be all right, Sect Leader Song? My son was beaten like a street dog, and now we're expected to apologize on top of that. And Lord Tae, if I retreat now, what do you think the Jin Family of Taiyuan will make of it? Do you even hear yourselves?"

"…"

"…"

The two men who had spoken flinched after drawing his ire, while the other two breathed sighs of relief.

But inwardly, all four were thinking the same thing.

This damned merchant. I ought to just…

They were only tolerating him because they still needed the Seongun Escort Bureau's support.

They remembered clearly what their sons had told them.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi said he would make the Seongun Escort Bureau an example.

Chief Woo and that man are both formidable… Unless they're the Nine Sects and One Gang, do they really think they can swallow the whole bureau in one bite?

Given the Jin Family of Taiyuan's recent power, they might be able to.

For now, we watch.

If the balance tipped even slightly, they would have to switch sides. The four sect leaders were each waiting for the right moment, and as long as their own families survived, they were perfectly willing to keep smiling at Woo Hwangtae.

"Ha-ha, Chief Woo. Calm yourself."

"Indeed. You and we have all been wronged, haven't we? We understand how you feel."

"Let's head inside. We can't stand here watching forever."

"Here, these pills came from a renowned physician. They can calm even the fiercest temper. Let's each chew one before we go in."

"Hoo…"

Woo Hwangtae released a heated sigh and was about to toss the pill into his mouth when—

"Wow, this place is crawling with people. Absolutely crawling."

Along with the booming voice, something shoved against his arm. The pill dropped, and someone immediately stepped on it.

"…!"

That was the limit of Woo Hwangtae's patience. He glared at the culprit, his eyes blazing.

The man stood a full two heads taller than everyone around him. Between his cow-like eyes and the way he was picking his nose, he looked every inch a country bumpkin.

"You! Stop right there!"

The huge man stopped in his tracks.

"Huh? Me?"

“Yes, you bastard! If you bump into someone, you should apologize immediately!”

“Ah. There were so many people, I didn’t notice. Sorry ‘bout that.”

The man promptly bowed and turned away, but that only made Woo Hwangtae’s temper flare hotter.

His son’s humiliation. The memory of being disregarded by the gate guard for days. And now the behavior of this oversized country bumpkin.

The fuse had been lit.

“You ox-headed bastard! Stop right there!”

The giant flinched.

“What did you just say?”

“I called you an ox-headed bastard. You’re lower than an ox, you son of a bitch!”

“That’s one of the things I hate most.”

“If you hate it, what are you going to do about it?”

The giant snorted a plume of breath before opening his mouth.

“Can I hit him?”

“You bastard, I’ll kill—!”

Just as Woo Hwangtae was about to strike, a clear voice came from behind him.

“No.”

The speaker was a clean-cut young man.

Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong, had stopped his Junior Brother just before he exploded. He smiled at Woo Hwangtae.

Chapter 181

“You cause trouble whenever I take my eyes off you, even for a moment.”

After lightly scolding his Junior Brother, Baek Museong bowed his head to Woo Hwangtae.

“It seems there was a minor misunderstanding between you. I hope you’ll be generous enough to forgive him.”

His voice was as gentle as his appearance.

Woo Hwangtae was closer to a merchant than a martial artist. His martial arts were First Rate, but he could pride himself on having a Peak-level eye for people and situations, honed through years of running an Escort Bureau.

Under normal circumstances, one look at Baek Museong might have brought a certain phrase to mind.

The extraordinary hidden within the ordinary.

Unfortunately, Woo Hwangtae was not in his right mind.

Baek Museong had stepped in out of nowhere, and his clean-cut appearance made him seem like an easy mark. His polite voice carried the composure of a powerful man, but to Woo Hwangtae, it sounded merely insolent.

“What was that? You want me to generously forgive him?”

His voice seethed with rage as he raised an eyebrow.

“How dare you tell me what to do?”

“That was not my intention, but if I’ve offended you, I apologize.”

“Apologize? Hah. You little pup.”

Crack.

Once anger took hold, it naturally clouded a person’s judgment.

Woo Hwangtae clenched his fists and stepped forward, but the other Sect Leaders hurriedly tried to restrain him.

“Chief Woo, it would be best to stop here.”

“Sect Leader Song is right. Nothing good will come of making a scene.”

“Some arrogant bastards who crawled in from God knows where insult me, and you expect me to take it? Do you all look down on me too?”

“No, that’s not what we meant.”

“Then what are you trying to say?”

His tone was now only a hair short of openly speaking down to them. The Sect Leaders of the Five Gates of Shanxi frowned inwardly, but they still had to prevent an unnecessary conflict.

“We only mean that this is the wrong time and place. Have you forgotten our situation?”

“If you insist, I won’t stop you, but… there’s no need to cause a scene when we’re already in the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s bad books.”

“We understand that you’re angry, but please think of our position too. We’re all trying to survive here.”

Again. Again with the damned Jin Family of Taiyuan!

Woo Hwangtae barely swallowed the curses threatening to burst from his mouth. If not for the countless eyes and ears around him, he would have spewed every insult he knew and smashed everything in sight.

But his last shred of reason held him back.

“Nggh.”

After barely calming himself, Woo Hwangtae glared at Baek Museong, who still stood there looking perfectly composed.

“I’d like nothing more than to beat you to death with a single blow right now, but… I’ll let it pass as a country bumpkin’s mistake. Get lost before I change my mind.”

Baek Museong regarded him for a moment, then bowed his head.

“Thank you for your consideration.”

“Hmph. Lucky bastards.”

But Woo Hwangtae was the lucky one.

If Baek Museong hadn’t sent a Sound Transmission a moment earlier, he would have been hovering between life and death by now.

“Second, stop.”

Chulwoo, the second of the Three Plum Blossom Elites and known as the Defeated Flower Fist, stopped dead just as he was about to launch himself forward.

A voice no one else could hear slipped between his teeth.

“He wasn’t satisfied with going after me—he even went after you, Senior Brother.”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“It matters to me. Can’t I hit him once? Just once?”

“That sounds like you want to beat him to death.”

“…I’ll hit him gently. Just once. Really.”

“That sounds like you want to gently beat him to death. Have you forgotten Master’s strict order not to attract unnecessary attention?”

Chulwoo wrestled with himself for a moment before lowering his tightly clenched fist.

“Whew. This is driving me crazy.”

Baek Museong gave his shoulder an approving pat.

“You showed restraint. This too is training.”

“How is this training? What’s the point of learning martial arts if I can’t use them when the time comes?”

“Indiscriminate killing will only ruin you. Martial arts are meant to cultivate essence, qi, and spirit, not to kill people.”

“Every time I look at you, I get confused. Am I a disciple of Huashan or a monk from Shaolin Temple?”

“Could someone with your personality possibly become a monk? I already pity all the wooden fish[1002] you’d smash.”

Baek Museong let out a quiet laugh, and Chulwoo sighed.

He deeply respected his Senior Brother, but the man was simply too kindhearted. That was the problem.

“Those bastards should have their mouths smashed in…”

“Hey, watch your mouth!”

“All right, all right.”

Chulwoo watched Woo Hwangtae’s back as he grew smaller in the distance and smacked his lips.

I’ve memorized his face. Just let me catch him once.

Baek Museong knew exactly what his Junior Brother was thinking. He shook his head.

“Enough foolish thoughts. Find the youngest.”

“Did Eunhyang disappear again?”

“Yes. Just like you did.”

Chulwoo flinched.

“I-I went to take a leak.”

“That’s right. But why did someone who went to take a leak end up picking a fight in the middle of a crowd?”

“It happened on my way back after I’d finished. Wait, Senior Brother, do you not believe me? I haven’t washed my hands yet. Want to smell them?”

“…Never mind.”

Baek Museong rubbed his temple. He cherished his Junior Brothers more than anyone, but they were exceptionally difficult to handle.

At least Chulwoo was big enough to find quickly. Their youngest Junior Disciple, Eunhyang, was practically invisible in a crowd like this.

“Do you see anything?”

Chulwoo, who was at least two heads taller than everyone else, swept his gaze around.

“Not really. There are too many people.”

Even a Peak master’s eyes would struggle to find a small girl amid the endless, bustling mass.

[1002] A wooden fish is a hollow wooden percussion instrument struck to keep rhythm during Buddhist chanting.

The crowd was so large that merchants had even set up stalls here and there.

“By the way, was the Jin Family of Taiyuan always this big? I’d never even heard of it before we came.”

“Those in the know do. The current Sect Leader, the Shanxi Extraordinary Hero, is fairly well known, and so is the Heaven Shaking Sword, isn’t he?”

“I don’t know about the Shanxi Extraordinary Hero, but the Heaven Shaking Sword… Is that the fellow who’s supposedly one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?”

“Don’t call him that. Watch your mouth.”

“He’s just a bookworm who goes to an academy. In my opinion, Senior Brother is much more…”

“Hey. Where did you learn that nasty habit of judging people before you’ve even met them? He is clearly a remarkable talent.”

“Well, for someone from Shanxi Province, being that good is practically a dragon rising from a ditch.”

Chulwoo answered indifferently, then suddenly frowned.

“Wasn’t there someone else besides the Heaven Shaking Sword? Some other dragon—or was it a loach?”

“A dragon? Do you mean the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“Ah, right. The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.”

“I hear he’s quite talented, though not as much as the Heaven Shaking Sword.”

“Dragon or loach, I’ve heard about him nonstop on the way here. I should at least take a look at his face.”

The corner of Baek Museong’s mouth lifted as he watched Chulwoo clench his fists.

“Do you want to spar with him?”

Chulwoo scratched the back of his head.

“Not particularly. I’d win anyway.”

“Competitive spirit is a good thing, but avoid causing trouble if you can.”

“What trouble could there be? Since we came all this way, I just want to see what he can do.”

Baek Museong studied his Second Junior Brother.

Despite what Chulwoo said, his curiosity was obvious.

After spending years cooped up on Huashan, facing the same people every day, he seemed excited to finally be out in the world.

“You’ll see him soon enough. Of course, we need to find the youngest first.”

The final words came out almost as a sigh.

The gates of the Jin Family of Taiyuan were already open, and the invited guests were streaming inside like clouds.

Baek Museong was wondering whether he would have to climb a tree when—

“Senior Brother, it’s all right if I make a little noise, isn’t it?”

“What?”

Chulwoo grinned and drew a deep breath.

The next instant, a thunderous shout erupted.

“Eun—hyang!”

Baek Museong had no time to stop him. Chulwoo’s voice was every bit as tremendous as his body.

The people around them clapped their hands over their ears and dropped to the ground, while the countless people who had been laughing and chatting abruptly fell silent.

As a hush descended over the crowd like a bucket of cold water—

“Big Brothers! I’m over here!”

Far in the distance, Chulwoo spotted a young girl eagerly jumping up and down in place. He spoke triumphantly.

“Ha-ha! Senior Brother, I found her!”

“…Yes, well done. Very well done.”

Baek Museong put a hand to his head.

Just then—

Whoosh.

Hundreds of people began murmuring as they parted like a field of reeds before the wind.

At the end of the open path stood a man like an iron tower. Chulwoo muttered without realizing it,

“Is that a man or a bear?”

“He’s a man. If not for him, the Jin Family of Taiyuan would not be what it is today.”

Baek Museong respectfully offered a cupped-fist salute to the bear-like man, Jin Wikyung.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The scenery whipped past us. Hyuk Mujin, riding beside me, shouted over the pounding hooves.

“We were definitely slow on the way there, but we’re incredibly fast coming back. Is it because we took our time two days ago?”

“Everything happens for a reason.”

“What reason?”

“We move faster when no one tries to stuff his face while riding a horse.”

"Ah."

Cheongpung had looked gloomy the entire trip. Before we left, I had stopped him from packing a mountain of food.

"I'm hungry."

I answered coldly.

"Endure it."

A Peak master's digestion was Peak-level too. Cheongpung crapped as much as he ate, then ate as much as he crapped.

And since he ate often, he naturally had to crap often…

Damn it. This is disgusting. I'll stop there.

"How far are we?"

"We just passed the ninth village, so… We should arrive in half a shichen[1003] at the earliest, or one full shichen[1004] at the latest."

The sunlight pouring down made my eyes sting. I looked up at the sun as it slowly climbed toward the middle of the sky.

"So we'll arrive around noon?"

"Probably."

"We're late, aren't we?"

"Of course we're late. Isn't that why we're riding like hell, trying to be a little less late?"

Fair point.

Instead of answering, I spurred my horse onward. With every stride, the long bundle strapped across my back thumped against the horse's back.

Ugh, what a pain.

The bundle contained the Unnamed Sword.

I was supposed to have returned it to Jeok Cheongang, but instead, I had somehow ended up taking it back.

As long as I lived in a Murim where the law was damn far away and fists were painfully close, I had no choice.

It's not like I can put it in my inventory either.

I could at least claim I had tucked the Flame Divine Palm martial arts manual inside my clothes. But if an entire sword suddenly popped out of my pocket, there would be no explaining that away.

If I were alone, it might be different. But with other people watching, it would be the perfect way to get accused of practicing demonic, heterodox arts.

[1003] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

[1004] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

I really got myself into a mess this time.

It wasn't that I resented being saddled with a troublesome object. I simply hated the thought of having to meet Fire King Jeok Cheongang—that terrifying old man—again.

"Let's meet again soon."

Meet again, my ass.

Every time I remembered what he had said a few shichen[1005] ago, my stomach churned.

Hyuk Mujin, who had been sneaking glances at me from time to time, asked,

"Why do you look like that?"

"I was thinking about the Fire King."

"Ugh. Life's too short for anything but happy thoughts, so why imagine something that horrible?"

"If you were me, wouldn't you think about him? He said he'd be back soon."

"Speaking of which, could you give me some time off? I suddenly miss my family."

"You bastard. You're trying to save yourself."

"You never know what might happen. Before I die, I should at least see my parents' faces one more time."

"That doesn't sound like something an unfilial son who hasn't shown his face in years should say."

"I'd like to take this opportunity to become a good son."

"Nope."

I dismissed Hyuk Mujin's bullshit and looked up at the sky with a sigh.

"Even the heavens are heartless. Why did that old man have to leave this thing with me?"

"He said it was a pain to carry around."

"For such a petty reason?"

"With him, I can completely believe it."

"…"

That was surprisingly convincing.

"I could lose it before he comes back. Or I could quietly pocket it for myself."

"You, Captain?"

Hyuk Mujin laughed as if he had just heard a brilliant joke.

"If you were that kind of person, what have you been doing all this time? If you hadn't been on the verge of death, you probably would've just kept the Blazing Flame Divine Pill too."

[1005] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

“That’s…”

He had a point.

“Just hide it somewhere no one will notice. Who knows? Maybe that great Fire King will teach you a move in return.”

“Teach me, my ass. I’m sure he’d love to teach the man who killed his Disciple.”

The absurdity drew a quiet laugh from me.

The Fire Gate Clan was said to pass its arts down to a single successor and never teach outsiders. Even setting personal feelings aside, the idea that he would teach martial arts to an outsider like me was ridiculous.

“Your nonsense is only funny in moderation, you idiot.”

“Well, now that you mention it, I suppose you’re right.”

At that moment, Cheongpung—who had been drooping like a corpse and endlessly repeating that he was hungry—spoke up.

“Isn’t he trying to take you as his Disciple, Benefactor?”

“…”

“…”

“Maybe not? I think he is. Grandpa Jeok seemed to be watching you closely, Benefactor.”

“Me?”

“Captain?” Hyuk Mujin asked.

Our gazes met in midair. Hyuk Mujin looked utterly baffled. I was probably making the same face.

We both let out disbelieving laughs.

“That’s great. Congratulations in advance, Captain.”

“Yeah. Thanks.”

Me? Someone he’d known for barely a day or two?

The idea was so absurd it didn’t even qualify as a joke.

“Maybe not? Or am I right?”

As Cheongpung tilted his head over his own bizarre suggestion, Hyuk Mujin raised a finger and pointed into the distance.

“Can you see it?”

I could.

People were walking down a well-kept road. Farther ahead lay a broad expanse of land surrounded by a teeming crowd.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I was back after three days away.

Chapter 182

Step. Step.

Under countless watchful eyes, two men walked toward each other. When they finally came face-to-face, they exchanged cupped-fist salutes.

“I am Jin Wikyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“I’m Baek Museong of Huashan.”

Huashan.

And Baek Museong.

Those two names alone carried tremendous weight.

Exclamations erupted from every direction, instantly shattering the silence.

“Huashan!”

“Baek Museong! It’s Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong!”

Though ordinary civilians were mixed in among them, a considerable number of those gathered here today were martial artists.

The name of Huashan and the epithet Huashan’s Lone Crane carried immense prestige.

“My heavens, why did Huashan’s Lone Crane come here?”

“Was the Jin Family of Taiyuan really this influential?”

“W-Wait. If Huashan’s Lone Crane came here, then…”

The people who had been talking over one another began scanning the area. Before long, they spotted the man and woman beside Baek Museong, and another round of exclamations broke out.

“That young man must be the Defeated Flower Fist. He’s enormous, just like I heard.”

“The Flower Sword Phoenix is here too! She’s even beautiful!”

“Whoa! It’s the Three Plum Blossom Elites!”

Chulwoo and Eunhyang looked bewildered by the unexpectedly fervent reception.

Both had accompanied their Master, the Heavenly Sword True Person, into the martial world a few times, but neither had ever received cheers like these.

“What the hell? Am I really this famous? They even know my epithet?”

“Senior Brother Chul, did you hear that? Someone just called me beautiful.”

Chulwoo’s expression turned stern.

“You heard wrong. Pay it no mind.”

“…You’re seriously annoying.”

They had trained together under the same Master since childhood and grown up like brother and sister. Jin Wikyung smiled faintly as they glared daggers at each other.

“You two seem close.”

“They’re still immature and constantly causing trouble. They have a long way to go.”

“Ha-ha. The Defeated Flower Fist and the Flower Sword Phoenix are both outstanding young prodigies. Surely that can’t be true.”

“You flatter us.”

A faint smile touched Baek Museong’s lips. Though this was their first meeting, he found himself liking Jin Wikyung.

Perhaps it was because of the man’s distinctive way of putting people at ease. Or perhaps it was his familiar bulk, which reminded Baek Museong of Chulwoo.

“Let us go inside. This is hardly the place for an important conversation.”

“I agree.”

They had already drawn attention unintentionally.

If even a single word about the Sword Saint slipped out with so many people watching, there would undoubtedly be an uproar.

“Well, then.”

Jin Wikyung dipped his head and led the way.

Baek Museong followed amid the cheers and countless stares, only to stop short.

He could no longer sense his junior disciples behind him.

What is it?

Baek Museong glanced back and saw Chulwoo standing tall as an iron tower, staring intently at something.

“Second.”

At Baek Museong’s call, Chulwoo slowly turned his head.

“Yes, Senior Brother.”

“Is something wrong?”

“No. Nothing.”

Eunhyang, who was standing beside Chulwoo, abruptly cut in.

“That’s not true. Senior Brother Chul was staring at someone just now.”

“Do you know that person?”

Chulwoo immediately shook his head. His massive frame subtly blocked Eunhyang from view.

“As if. Other than going out a couple of times with our Master, I’ve been cooped up at headquarters the whole time.”

“That is… true.”

“My stomach suddenly started hurting, so I was only looking for a privy.”

“Really?”

“Yes. So, if you don’t mind, could I stop by the privy before we go?”

“How long has it been since you last took a piss?”

Chulwoo deliberately hardened his expression.

“If you take care of the big business first, the small business gets taken care of at the same time. But you can’t take care of the big business while doing the small business.”

“…Uh, sure.”

Baek Museong felt vaguely uneasy.

Perhaps it was because his Second Junior Brother, who usually rambled on without making a lick of sense, had answered so smoothly.

“Second, are you thinking about something else—”

He could not finish.

Jin Wikyung had stopped and was looking back at them in puzzlement.

“Young Hero Baek, is something the matter?”

“Oh, no. My junior disciple said he had an urgent matter.”

“What sort of matter?”

“Well… he needs to relieve himself.”

“Oh.”

The people who had been listening closely snickered. Chulwoo scratched the back of his head awkwardly.

“I apologize.”

“Not at all. You must be exhausted after traveling all the way to our family. You should take this opportunity to rest properly.”

Baek Museong considered it for a moment, then nodded. The important conversation was between him and Jin Wikyung anyway. Better to let his junior disciples rest than have them standing beside him and yawning their heads off.

“Great Hero Jin has given you permission, so go ahead.”

“Big Bro—no, Senior Brother. Can I go too?”

“Yes. Do you dislike it?”

“Yes. I just want to stay beside Senior Brother.”

Eunhyang nodded vigorously, and Jin Wikyung smiled.

“Then that settles it. Young Hero Baek?”

“Ah, yes. Let us go.”

Baek Museong resumed walking, still looking unconvinced. Before long, however, he put the matter out of his mind.

Surely nothing could happen in such a short time.

As Chulwoo watched the group recede into the distance, a martial artist from the Jin Family of Taiyuan approached him.

“I’ll guide you to the privy.”

“What do I need a privy for?”

“Pardon?”

“We’re surrounded by mountains. I can just take a dump by the side of the road. Don’t you agree?”

The people surrounding them burst into loud laughter.

There was a common prejudice that members of the Nine Sects and One Gang[1006] would be arrogant and rude. But Chulwoo’s refreshing banter made everyone feel as if a weight had been lifted from their chests.

“Of course. That’s right.”

“Though this is the frontier, the mountain scenery around here is beautiful. Go take care of your business while enjoying the view!”

“Hey, Defeated Flower Fist! Since fate brought us together, would you like me to recommend a scenic spot?”

Chulwoo threw back his head and roared with laughter.

“Ha-ha-ha! A scenic spot? Sounds good. But I don’t want to go to the place where you took a dump. Let’s see…”

Chulwoo casually swept his gaze over the crowd, then raised a finger and pointed at one man.

“How about that Brother over there guides me?”

The middle-aged man who had been staring blankly at Chulwoo all this time jolted in surprise.

“M-Me?”

“That’s right. You.”

The middle-aged man was Woo Hwangtae, and his face turned the color of shit.

“Slow down a little. Let’s take it easy from here.”

“Why?”

“Can’t you see the horse is foaming at the mouth? And if we arrive panting and out of breath, everyone will look at us and think, *Ah, that bastard was late.*”

“That makes a strange amount of sense.”

We gradually eased up on the reins. As we descended the hill, the Jin Family of Taiyuan slowly came into view below.

“By the way, there sure are a lot of people.”

[1006] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations in Murim.

"Seriously. From what I heard, they weren't supposed to invite anywhere near that many."

Even a rough count put the crowd camped out before the main gate of the Jin Family of Taiyuan well over several hundred.

Though we were still quite far away, we could even hear faint cheers.

Did an idol show up or something?

I drew on my internal energy and focused on my ears. My hearing, now several times sharper than usual, picked up every cheer from the crowd.

Hyuk Mujin quietly watched me for a moment before asking, "What's going on? Did they say an important guest arrived?"

"Huashan's Last Crane and the Plum Blossom Cutoff, apparently."

"…Those are epithets?"

"Don't ask me. That's what I heard."

We were still pretty far away, so there was a limit to what I could make out.

Still, what kind of epithets were those? Did the Plum Blossom Cutoff have some sort of grudge against Huashan?

At that moment, Cheongpung, who had been lying facedown across his horse's neck, spoke.

"Benefactor. They said Huashan's Lone Crane and the Three Plum Blossom Elites."

"Oh, really?"

"Yes. I heard them clearly."

He could hear that from this distance?

Cheongpung was the strongest martial artist among us, so he was probably right.

"I see."

While I merely nodded without much interest, Hyuk Mujin was so shocked that he nearly fell off his horse.

"H-Huashan's Lone Crane! The Three Plum Blossom Elites!"

"Are they famous?"

"Famous? That's putting it mildly! They're the direct disciples of the Heavenly Sword True Person, the Sect Leader of Huashan!"

"Is this one of those things where you'd have to be an idiot not to know them?"

"No martial artist could possibly not know them!"

"Oh, really?"

I casually pointed behind me. Cheongpung was staring wide-eyed and clapping.

"Wow, those are cool epithets. But where did they say they were from?"

"…"

"…"

"Shaolin Temple, maybe?"

Was he insane?

This was coming from the youngest Junior Brother of Huashan's Sect Leader himself.

After a long silence, Hyuk Mujin finally spoke.

"Huashan's Lone Crane. The Three Plum Blossom Elites. You really haven't heard of them?"

"I like Huashan! I like plum blossoms even more!"

"…Right."

Style was temporary, but class was forever.

It wasn't even "I like Dad, but I like Mom more." What the hell was this?

Was Huashan filed away in his head as Dad and plum blossoms as Mom?

While I pondered the workings of Cheongpung's mind, Hyuk Mujin finally collected himself and reached a conclusion.

"Anyway, they're insanely famous."

"I see."

"I see."

"…Is that really all the reaction you've got?"

"What kind of reaction were you expecting?"

"Most people would react like I did."

"So I'm supposed to be so shocked that I fall off my horse?"

Hyuk Mujin climbed back into the saddle and launched into an impassioned speech.

"That's how big a deal they are! The Heavenly Sword True Person's disciples! The future of Huashan!"

"I see. They're no joke."

I turned toward Cheongpung.

"May I ask your grandfather's full name?"

"His surname is Mae, and his given name uses the characters Jong and Hak. Mae Jonghak."

"And his epithet?"

"The Sword Saint."

"Did you hear that, Mujin?"

"Yes."

Hyuk Mujin nodded with a blank expression, then came to his senses. His eagerness to make us understand how extraordinary Huashan's Lone Crane and the Three Plum Blossom Elites were was almost palpable.

"Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint, doesn't count. Honestly, that would be like an adult joining a children's fight."

"So what's your conclusion?"

"Huashan's Lone Crane is already a master who has surpassed the level of a young prodigy. At this rate, becoming the next Sect Leader won't be a problem. The other two members of the Three Plum Blossom Elites are objects of admiration among young martial artists too."

They really were impressive. From the way he talked about young prodigies, they still seemed to be quite young, yet the public considered them at least world-class.

"Then why am I not particularly impressed?"

"That… I'm not sure."

Hyuk Mujin thought about it carefully, then his expression suddenly went flat.

"Now that I think about it, I'm not exactly bursting with excitement either."

"Really?"

"Yes. Huashan's Lone Crane used to be my idol."

Cheongpung abruptly cut in.

"Isn't it because of Grandpa Jeok?"

"Huh?"

"Eh?"

"He's incredibly strong. And he's trying to take you as his Disciple."

The second part was complete bullshit, but the first part was right.

If the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, was something above the clouds that I could not even properly picture in my mind, the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was a monster that had revealed itself in the flesh.

After experiencing a monster larger than a hundred-story building, it was only natural that a monster the size of a four-story commercial building would make less of an impression.

"And…"

Cheongpung looked straight at me and continued slowly.

"You're plenty strong, Benefactor."

"…What?"

"I mean it."

Something tickled in one corner of my chest, but he was undeniably right about that too.

It wasn't that I thought I could fight Huashan's Lone Crane right now without falling behind.

I was certain I could catch up to him before long.

It had taken me only a few months to go from a Third Rate martial artist who knew nothing about martial arts to a Peak master.

I couldn't even begin to imagine how much I might grow in another year or two.

To me, Huashan's Lone Crane was a milestone along the road—not an impassable wall.

"Thanks for saying that."

Cheongpung answered with a sunny smile.

"You're welcome. Grandpa said weak martial artists without firm resolve need constant attention."

"…"

Fuck me. It had just been a pep talk.

I was wrestling with the urge to split open the crown of Cheongpung's head when —

"H-Hey, Young Hero Chul!"

"Hah, listen to this old coot calling me Young Hero Chul. Didn't you call me a cow's head earlier?"

"N-No, Great Hero Chul! I committed a grave discourtesy, *-so*!"[1007]

"Committed-*so*? *-so*? Cow? You just called me a cow again, didn't you?"[1008]

"Eeeeeek! Isn't that taking it too far? Do you even know how old I am?"

"Yes, Elder. Let's head up there and have a little talk."

A young man with a massive build reminiscent of Jin Wikyung was dragging a middle-aged man behind him.

Just as they were about to enter the mountainside beside the hill, the young man spotted us and stopped.

"Brother over there, do you need something?"

He means me, right?

[1007] The formal Korean sentence ending *-so* is pronounced the same as the Korean word for "cow."

[1008] The formal Korean sentence ending *-so* is pronounced the same as the Korean word for "cow."

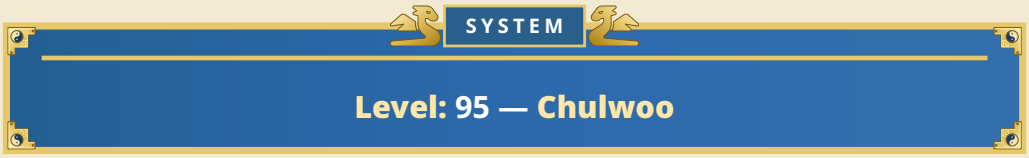
Chapter 183

A hulking man reminiscent of a Minotaur glared at me with enormous, bulging eyes.

“Brother over there, do you need something?”

He was telling me to pretend I hadn’t seen anything and move along.

It was no different from something a third-rate thug in a movie might say, but according to Qi Sense, this hulking man was neither a third-rate thug nor some inept wandering martial artist.



He’s as skilled as he looks.

In Murim terms, he was a Peak master. In modern terms, he was at least an A-rank Hunter.

If a guy like that were a thug, forget the police—the people’s cane. Even the people’s sledgehammer wouldn’t be enough.

Where did this guy come from?

For a moment, the epithets I’d just heard—Huashan’s Lone Crane and the Three Plum Blossom Elites—flashed through my mind, but that was as far as it went.

No matter how I looked at him, he seemed more like the Majang-dong[1009] Knifeman or Seocho-dong Twin Axes than a crane or a plum blossom. Those sorts of nicknames suited him much better.

When I merely stared without answering, the hulking man—Chulwoo—frowned.

“Didn’t you hear me? Are you deaf? Or mute?”

Before I could say anything, Hyuk Mujin jumped in.

“What an outrageous fellow. How dare you speak so rudely to our Young Master?”

“And pretending not to hear someone is polite?”

“Ahem!”

“What are you ahem-ing about? How important do you think you are, refusing to answer when someone speaks to you?”

“You insolent bastard! Do you need a beating to come to your senses?”

I stopped Hyuk Mujin as he reached for his sword scabbard.

“That’s enough.”

“Please don’t stop me. Someone like him needs to be taught a harsh lesson!”

“He’s stronger than you.”

[1009] Majang-dong is a Seoul neighborhood known for its livestock and meat markets.

“Ah. I don’t think this is my place to step in.”

“…”

“…”

Chulwoo opened his mouth with an incredulous expression.

“Is he your subordinate?”

“For now.”

“You must have a hard time.”

“Every day is a battle against my own patience.”

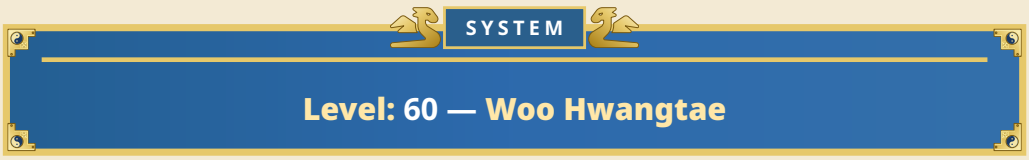
After looking our group up and down, Chulwoo clicked his tongue.

“You look like martial artists, so you’d be better off going on your way. This man wronged me badly.”

Chulwoo grabbed *this man* by the collar and lifted him. He was so strong that the heavyset middle-aged man shot straight into the air.

“Eeeek! H-Help me!”

Above the terrified middle-aged man’s head floated the Level window I had detected earlier with Qi Sense.



That was a name that made me crave hangover soup.[1010]

It also sounded vaguely familiar.

Woo Hwangtae, Woo Hwangtae… Where have I heard that before?

While I was thinking, Chulwoo shook Woo Hwangtae violently by the collar.

“What do you mean, help you? Don’t drag innocent people into this. Just take a few hits and get it over with.”

“G-Great Hero, please don’t do this. Let’s resolve it through conversation. Conversation.”

“Conversation?”

“Y-Yes! Conversation!”

“Conversation sounds good. Then let’s go somewhere without any people around and have a nice, intimate chat.”

He clearly meant to have a physical conversation.

Woo Hwangtae, who was being dragged away against his will, screamed,

“I-I was invited here by the Jin Family of Taiyuan! I’m supposed to have a private audience with the Lesser Family Head!”

[1010] *Hwangtae* is dried pollock, an ingredient in soup commonly eaten as a hangover remedy.

“So was I. And I’m a simple, crude man by nature, so I don’t particularly care whether you’re meeting the Lesser Family Head or the Family Head.”

“Eeeeeek!”

This wouldn’t do. Someone was going to die before I remembered his name.

I had no desire to get dragged into an unnecessary dispute, but simply walking past didn’t sit right with me either.

From the sound of it, he’s a fairly important guest.

The fact that he was supposed to meet privately with Jin Wikyung bothered me, as did Chulwoo’s casual disparagement of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I smacked my lips and stepped forward.

“Excuse me.”

“All that fat and you still have to make people’s lives difficult… Did you call me?”

“Yes.”

“What do you want?”

“It’s nothing important.”

Chulwoo paused, and I continued.

“It’s a good day. Wouldn’t it be better to talk things out?”

“You want me to stop?”

“I’m sorry for sticking my nose where it doesn’t belong, but wouldn’t it look bad for the Jin Family of Taiyuan if its guests started fighting on a day like this?”

“Listen, Young Hero.”

Chulwoo rubbed his neck with an annoyed expression. At the same time, he dropped what little politeness remained in his speech.

“This is personal. If you get involved, you’ll only make trouble for yourself.”

“I’m already tired of this. What can you do?”

“You’re getting awfully informal.”

“Yep. Right back at you.”

“How old are you?”

“Twenty.”

“Twenty? Ha. Still green. Nice and green.”

“How old are you?”

“I’m twenty-five, you young bastard.”

Good grief. I was surprised twice.

Once by the boomer attitude of a twenty-five-year-old, and again by the fact that his face belonged to a man in his mid-twenties.

Even if he had been fed protein supplements instead of breast milk as a baby, he shouldn’t have ended up like this. I asked with considerable astonishment,

"Twenty-five? Is your name Benjamin[1011] or something? You're living your life backward all by yourself."

Benjamin Chulwoo glared at me.

"What kind of bullshit is that?"

"It's not bullshit. It's a fact. Looking that old must have made life tough."

"Old? Shut up! Everyone around me says I look young!"

"Everyone around you? Number one, your mother. Number two, your father. Number three, your grandmother. Pick one of the three. Oh, let's make number four your youngest aunt."

"You beardless little brat…"

"Pull down your pants. I want to see whether you've got hair on your dick."

"You little—!"

"Woof, woof-woof! Woof-woof-woof!"

Chulwoo released Woo Hwangtae's collar. Trembling as he looked back and forth between earth and sky, he drew a deep breath.

"You… Hoo. Hoooo."

"Are you angry, Benjamin[1012]?"

"Shut that damn mouth!"

He seemed to have completely lost his temper.

I didn't mean to take it this far.

I had merely returned each insult as it came, and somehow this was where we had ended up.

Snorting like a frenzied Minotaur, Chulwoo finally managed to force the words out. With great difficulty. Tremendous difficulty.

"Y-You bastard, what the hell are you?"

"What kind of bastard do you think I am?"

"A bastard who's gone mad wanting to die."

Crack.

Bones shifted with an ugly crunch inside his fist, which was as thick as a shovel handle.

Chulwoo ground his teeth and glared at me.

"Do you even know what it means to interfere in someone else's personal gratitude and grudges in Murim?"

"I already apologized for sticking my nose where it doesn't belong. But if guests start throwing punches, what does that make the people who invited them? You ought to consider our family's position too."

"Our family?"

[1011] Benjamin refers to Benjamin Button, a fictional character who ages backward.

[1012] Benjamin refers to Benjamin Button, a fictional character who ages backward.

"Yeah. Our family."

"Are you perhaps a member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"I'm no household parasite, if that's what you mean."

"Make one more wordplay joke, and I'll put you in bed for three years."

"Watch your mouth—unless you want your family observing three years of mourning.[1013]"

Chulwoo smiled thinly. It wasn't a smile born of amusement. It was the kind of smile that appeared on its own when someone's anger had reached the top of his head.

"My Senior Brother warned me over and over… but I can't let you off. Time for you to take a few hits."

Boom!

Before he could finish speaking, an enormous roar rang out, and the ground shattered.

The two-meter-tall[1014] giant launched himself like a cannonball. The time it took him to reach the tip of my nose was no more than an instant.

"It's going to hurt."

Whoosh!

With a chilling voice, the air scattered.

No—it was crushed.

It was nothing more than a simple punch, with no form or martial principle added to it. The force contained in that fist exploded with enough momentum to shatter a thousand-geun[1015] boulder.

But…

It doesn't matter if it doesn't hit me.

Bang! B-bang!

I bent backward as if lying down. The fist tore through the air a handspan above me, compressed air exploding from its tip. A tree about ten feet away went flying as if caught in a typhoon.

Wow. This guy was serious.

I had to marvel at the sheer power.

If an ordinary First Rate master had taken that blow, it would not have ended with mere pain. Once Chulwoo lost his temper, he seemed unable to see anything else.

"Hey, hey. Take it easy. Take it easy."

"You rat-like bastard!"

[1013] Three years of mourning was a traditional period of mourning for a parent in Korean and Chinese custom.

[1014] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

[1015] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

Whoosh! Whoooosh!

One punch, two punches, three. Each time I easily dodged another blow, my suspicion hardened into certainty.

I think I can win.

Even a thousand-geun[1016] boulder had to be hit before it could be shattered.

No matter how powerful an attack was, it meant nothing if it failed to connect.

Moreover, Chulwoo had only just entered the Peak realm and couldn't even project Fist Energy. If our martial insight was comparable, I had an overwhelming advantage.

Because I possessed a special power no one else had.

Stats.

Whoooosh! Bang!

After yet another wild swing, Chulwoo exploded in frustration.

"What the hell!"

"You're too worked up. Take a deep breath and relax. Then you might manage to touch a single hair on my head."

Meanwhile, I had completely regained my composure. Hyuk Mujin and Cheongpung were watching from the sidelines as if none of this concerned them, while Woo Hwangtae stared at our exchange with his mouth hanging open.

Given how things were going, Chulwoo also seemed considerably flustered.

"What the hell are you?"

"A member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"There's no way someone like you could be in this backwater… Wait."

Chulwoo stared intently at me, then suddenly narrowed his eyes.

"Are you the Heaven Shaking Sword?"

"I'm somewhat related to him. As far as I know, we came out of the same womb."

"Then… are you the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

I grinned.

"Bingo."

He might not have known what *bingo* meant, but he understood that it meant yes and clenched his fist.

"I knew you had some skill."

"Try hitting me at least once before saying that. You said it would hurt, but this just feels refreshing."

"I'll admit it. You may not be a dragon, but you could at least qualify as an imugi.[1017]"

[1016] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

[1017] An *imugi* is a legendary serpent said to have the potential to become a dragon.

“Good grief, that’s a harsh assessment.”

“Your mouth has reached the realm of transcendence.”

“It’s all psychological warfare. Take a look at yourself. Your eyes are rolled back, and you keep swinging at thin air.”

“Don’t get the wrong idea. I simply had no desire to use my sect’s martial arts against a nameless small fry like you.”

“Which sect is that? The Dodong Sect?”

“You don’t need to know.”

He spat out a wad of phlegm and muttered,

“Damn it, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. That takes the fun out of it.”

Same for me.

He was obviously a disciple of a fairly well-known sect, but if we fought until one of us fell, both of us would have to deal with the backlash.

“I’m holding back because of my eldest brother.”

“I’ll let you off because of my Senior Brother.”

We spoke at nearly the same time and glared at each other.

“Oh? Look at this bastard.”

“Bastard? You little brat, how dare you speak to an adult that way!”

“Adult, my ass. Do you even know how old I am, calling yourself an adult?”

“What else is someone who’s barely twenty supposed to be but a child?”

“That’s not what I meant…!”

If I added my age in Murim to my age in the modern world, I was practically fifty. But there was no chance of getting that across to him.

I swallowed the words that were about to burst out.

“Forget it. What’s the point of talking to a guy like you? Anyway, in Murim, the strong are the adults.”

“What? Are you saying I’m weaker than you?”

“Obviously. Didn’t you feel the difference between us just now?”

“You son of a bitch! I could chew you up and still not feel satisfied!”

“Try hitting me, if you can.”

“You think I can’t?”

Just as Chulwoo raised his fist with a heavy snort, someone’s voice abruptly cut in.

“It would be best if you both stopped now.”

Wipeng descended with an elusive movement technique and swept us with a chilly gaze.

His eyes passed over Cheongpung, Hyuk Mujin, and Woo Hwangtae, who was a complete mess after being dragged around, before finally shooting toward Chulwoo and me like arrows.

“Defeated Flower Fist. Third Young Master.”

“No, Great Hero Wipeng. It’s not like that. The circumstances…”

“That’s right. I was merely…”

His voice, colder than the bitter winds and snow of the north, froze our next words solid.

“Are you both determined to bring utter shame upon your respective schools?”

Chulwoo and I quietly shut our mouths.

“How long has Defeated Flower Fist been gone?”

“Dunno. Feels like it’s been more than half an hour.”

“Why isn’t he back?”

“Maybe he’s blocked up.”

“A Daoist from Huashan?”

“Why would that matter? If he’s a Daoist from Huashan, does that mean his shit should come out smoothly too?”

“I suppose you’re right.”

Just as the theory that Chulwoo was constipated was all but confirmed, the people who spotted a party of riders coming down the hill burst into cheers.

Among them was a face no martial artist in Shanxi Province could possibly fail to recognize.

“It’s the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! He’s coming with the Defeated Flower Fist!”

“Wooaaah!”

The appearance of two young and outstanding men sent the crowd into a frenzy.

The two young prodigies whom everyone believed would become future leaders of Murim walked side by side, waving their hands.

Every time they did, cheers erupted from all directions, along with hands reaching out to touch even their clothing.

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

“The Defeated Flower Fist!”

“Well now, they look pretty close. Were they acquainted?”

“Does that matter? Real talent recognizes real talent. There’s nothing strange about them forming a deep friendship in such a short time.”

“Now that you mention it, that makes sense. They look great together.”

While everyone watched them with warm smiles, the beaming Jin Taekyung and Chulwoo exchanged words in voices so low they were barely audible.

“I let you off earlier. You know that, right? You couldn’t even touch me.”

“Bullshit. I didn’t use even half my strength.”

“I didn’t use even a third.”

“I misspoke. I didn’t use even one-tenth.”

“My mistake too. Truth is, I didn’t use even one percent.”

“Now that I think about it, neither did I.”

“Is this guy completely insane?”

“Who are you to say that?”

Amid the thunderous cheers, a fierce exchange unfolded—one only Peak masters could hear.

Chapter 184

There could be a thousand people, not merely hundreds. Escorted by martial artists from the Jin Family of Taiyuan, we pushed our way through the enormous crowd.

This feels amazing.

I felt like a star in the Chinese-speaking world. The Korean Wave[1018] and all that.

Then again, I really was Korean, so maybe that wasn't entirely wrong.

"Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Look this way just once!"

"Eeeek! Young Hero Jin!"

"Waaah!"

They say even a mutt has the advantage on its home turf.

No matter how famous the Three Plum Blossom Elites were, they couldn't beat the pride of Shanxi Province—the son of Taiyuan—on his own turf.

As I beamed and waved, Chulwoo whispered to me.

"Look at the corners of your mouth. Enjoying yourself?"

"Look at the corners of yours. Are you crying?"

"You Shanxi bumpkin."

"Yeah, next mountain man."

"You little—"

"What, you—"

Just as sparks were about to fly again, a thread of Sound Transmission pierced my ear.

Third Young Master!

Wipeng was glaring at me with a fierce expression. He looked like he wanted to slap me right then and there.

He must have sent a similar Sound Transmission to Chulwoo, because the man added a curt remark with a dissatisfied expression.

"I let you off."

I answered with a derisive snort.

When the crowd's cheers first told me that Chulwoo was a fairly prominent young prodigy of Huashan, I'd been rather surprised.

But that was all.

So what if he's one of the Three Plum Blossom Elites?

I'd already seen more than enough of Huashan's martial arts, thanks to a certain someone trudging along beside me.

[1018] The Korean Wave is the spread of South Korean popular culture, including music, television, and film, beyond Korea.

“I’m hungry. I’m hungry.”

“…”

Cheongpung was a strange guy no matter how many times I saw him, but there was no denying that he was a Peak master who had mastered Huashan’s supreme secret arts.

Thanks to him, I was confident I could counter whatever martial arts Chulwoo used. The only thing Chulwoo had over me was Huashan’s backing.

…

Ah, no. I take that back.

Now that I thought about it, the difference in our backgrounds was pretty serious. No matter how far the Jin Family of Taiyuan had risen, the Nine Sects and One Gang were overwhelmingly powerful.

Fuck. I lose.

The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were essentially Murim’s version of a corporate alliance.

A bunch of already powerful conglomerates had banded together to gang up on everyone else. Who could possibly stand against that?

Fortunately, for all their talk of being the orthodox faction, they didn’t encroach on the neighborhood markets. That was why small and medium-sized companies like the Jin Family of Taiyuan still had room to climb.

Seen that way, Huashan is clearly paying close attention to this matter.

Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong.

If everything Hyuk Mujin had told me was true, Baek Museong was practically the next Sect Leader of Huashan—recognized as such by everyone, including himself.

There was one person among Huashan’s young prodigies who could be considered his only equal, though…

“Benefactor, I’m really hungry. Do you have any dumplings left?”

“No. I don’t.”

“Oh. Aaaah…”

Cheongpung was a lost cause.

Huashan’s Daoists would probably convert to Islam before that guy became the Sect Leader of Huashan.

Even I, an outsider, couldn’t help thinking, *What kind of person is this?* How much worse must it be for the people of Huashan?

He’s the kind of guy who’ll experience everything the world has to offer, then decide he’d like to try being Huashan’s Sect Leader too. Yeah.

As I imagined this highly plausible future, Chulwoo spoke with an irritated look.

“What, are you possessed by the ghost of someone who died craving dumplings? Please shut up and walk.”

"…?"

"…?"

"…?"

Chulwoo flinched as Wipeng, Hyuk Mujin, and I all turned to stare at him.

"W-What? Why are you suddenly looking at me like that?"

"Hey, don't tell me…"

"Young Hero Chul, you don't know?"

"Come on, surely not. You're one of the Three Plum Blossom Elites. There's no way you wouldn't know."

As our reactions came one after another, Chulwoo's ox-like eyes darted around.

"What? Why is everyone acting like this?"

Why else? Because he couldn't recognize an elder of his own sect.

In terms of seniority, Cheongpung was the Sword Saint's Disciple and the youngest Junior Brother of the Heavenly Sword True Person, Huashan's current Sect Leader.

That made him Chulwoo's master's Junior Brother—in other words, his Martial Uncle.

Actually, now that I think about it, maybe he wouldn't know.

The Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, had raised Cheongpung while living in seclusion. Only a select few within Huashan could possibly know his face and identity.

I clicked my tongue at Chulwoo, who was standing right in front of his Martial Uncle without recognizing him.

"Tsk, tsk. It really is darkest beneath the lamp."

"What the hell are you talking about?"

"Never mind. You'll find out soon enough."

"Damn it, this is driving me insane."

As Chulwoo pounded his chest in frustration, we left the cheering crowd behind and passed through the main gate of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

At once, more than a hundred pairs of eyes turned toward us, accompanied by whispers from every direction. The atmosphere was completely different from the one outside the gate.

"That young man…"

"That's the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. He's every bit as handsome as I'd heard."

"The Defeated Flower Fist is here too. Isn't he the Heavenly Sword True Person's second Disciple?"

"Then who are the two young men beside them?"

"I couldn't tell you."

More than a hundred men and women of all ages mingled inside. Their clothes and bearing spoke of wealth and leisure.

The power players of Shanxi Province.

Some were Sect Leaders, while others were wealthy merchants. Every one of them possessed enough influence and ability to earn a formal invitation to this gathering.

At first glance, it almost looks like an aristocratic ball.

A strange feeling came over me as I walked on.

These people could be considered Shanxi Province's ruling class, yet they were merely supporting players at this gathering. Their curious, admiring gazes made something tickle in one corner of my chest.

Then it happened.

"My name is Jang Se-pal. I lead a small sect called the Hequ Sect."

"Ah, yes. Hello."

"I've long admired the reputation of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi from the bottom of my heart, and…"

The middle-aged martial artist launched into a long-winded speech about how honored he was to meet me. Then people began swarming toward us like a horde of Zombies.

"Greetings. I run a small martial arts academy near Yangcheon…"

"Pardon? Oh, yes."

"Young Hero Jin, I have something important to discuss with you. Perhaps we could move somewhere else…"

"Right now? That might be difficult."

"This is my daughter. She wanted to meet the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi at least once, so I brought her along. If you happen to find her appealing…"

"Yes, yes."

"Oh! Then shall I send a matchmaker at once?"

"Wait, wait! I answered that wrong!"

What the hell was going on?

Requests for handshakes—or rather, a barrage of fist-and-palm salutes—poured in from every direction. I was on the verge of losing my mind.

If Wipeng hadn't stepped forward at just the right moment, I would have ended up accepting every favor and marriage proposal wrapped in flowery language.

"Everyone, restrain yourselves!"

The shout of a Peak master infused with internal energy made the people flinch, and we took the opportunity to escape. Chulwoo clicked his tongue as though he'd had enough.

"That was excessive. Are all the people of Shanxi like that?"

Of course not. This was a special case.

Wipeng was the only member of our group who hadn't been flustered. He spoke with his usual calm expression.

"This will happen often from now on, so you should gradually get used to it."

"I'm supposed to experience things like this often?"

"You're a direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, after all."

"I almost got married five times just now."

"That's only natural for a promising young prodigy without a partner."

"I heard someone claim they were betrothed to me while we were still in the womb… Is that true?"

"What does it matter whether it's true or false? Look on the bright side."

My hair stood on end.

I'd spent twenty-seven years in the modern world without ever dating anyone, and now I was afraid I might suddenly end up in an arranged marriage.

In Murim, thousands of miles from home, no less.

No. I have Song-i.

Veins bulging in my neck, I shouted,

"Marriage is incredibly important! You can't just brush it aside like that! Love between a man and a woman! Pure feelings! Don't I get any of that?"

"No. You don't."

"Why?! How come?!"

Wipeng looked me up and down as if I were an insect.

"Is that something a man who's been frequenting pleasure houses since he was sixteen should say? Did you scatter your conscience along with your silver nyang[1019]?"

"…"

"Let's keep moving quietly. Our Lord is waiting."

If I'd actually been to one, at least I wouldn't have felt so wronged.

Fuck, I'd never even been to a pickup bar, let alone a pleasure house.

As I kept silent and wept tears of blood inside, Chulwoo sidled over and asked,

"Is that true?"

"What is?"

"That you've been visiting pleasure houses since you were sixteen."

"None of your business. Why are you suddenly asking?"

Chulwoo flinched and began to ramble.

"Well, how should I put it? Personal curiosity, perhaps. The curiosity of a man who has steadfastly walked only the path of a martial artist…"

[1019] A *nyang* is a historical Korean unit of currency. Here, "silver nyang" refers to silver money, not modern Korean won.

“You want to visit a pleasure house?”

“Ahem!”

“Finish walking the path of a martial artist. Don’t go wandering down side paths for no reason.”

I had barely finished answering with utter disdain when a voice cut in.

“Jin Taekyung is absolutely right. How long has it been since you descended from the main sect? Have you already forgotten the duty of a martial artist?”

The tone was stern, yet tinged with amusement.

The unfamiliar voice belonged to a clean-cut man. He approached with steady steps and respectfully offered a fist-and-palm salute.

But it wasn’t directed at me or Wipeng.

“Baek Museong, First-generation Disciple of Huashan, pays his respects to his Martial Uncle.”

Cheongpung remained silent for a moment before answering.

“Who are you?”

He looked to be around sixty.

The old man had a slender frame and strikingly narrow eyes.

A deeply hoarse voice rasped through his chapped lips.

“So you were utterly humiliated by some nameless nobody?”

“E-Elder, that isn’t what happened…”

The three men standing before him were sweating profusely.

They were known as the Three Hands of Zhongnan, but in the presence of an elder of their sect, they had to watch every word and every movement.

All the more so when that elder was the Roaring Fury Swordsman, a master counted among the five strongest in the Zhongnan Sect and a man notorious for his fiery temper.

“Then what happened? No matter how I listen to this, all these old ears hear is that you bastards smeared shit all over the name of the great Zhongnan Sect.”

The Three Hands of Zhongnan trembled beneath his piercing gaze.

Just as the Roaring Fury Swordsman was about to unleash his thunderous reprimand, one of the men, who had kept his mouth tightly shut the entire time, suddenly spoke.

“He wasn’t a nameless nobody.”

“What?”

Gong Ilhyuk, the man with a splint on his arm, continued.

“He said he was the Sword Saint’s Disciple.”

The revelation was so shocking that the Roaring Fury Swordsman fell speechless. After a moment, he asked in disbelief,

"…The Sword Saint?"

"Yes."

"The Sword Saint, who has lived in seclusion all these years, raised a Disciple?"

"We suspected it at first, but… it seems to be true."

"Your evidence?"

"Li Feng, a lay Disciple of Huashan, serves in the military of Shanxi Province. Judging by his reaction, there can be little doubt."

"Li Feng?"

The old man's already wrinkled brow furrowed further.

His memory wasn't sharp enough to recall some lay Disciple of Huashan.

"Is that all?"

At the lukewarm response, Gong Ilhyuk hurriedly continued.

"He has mastered Huashan's supreme secret arts to the Peak level despite being barely twenty. He displayed one martial art after another that only the main sect's direct Disciples are permitted to learn…"

After hearing the entire account of what had happened, the Roaring Fury Swordsman silently rubbed his sword scabbard.

The Sword Saint's Disciple. The Sword Saint's Disciple.

The Sword Saint had been in seclusion for decades.

No one even knew whether he was alive or dead, yet now his Disciple had suddenly appeared in Murim?

It was hard to believe, but the Roaring Fury Swordsman was already inclined to accept it.

At the very least, I should confirm it for myself.

After remaining silent for a long while, the Roaring Fury Swordsman abruptly rose from his seat. An order fell on the startled Three Hands of Zhongnan.

"Guide me."

"W-Where do you mean?"

"Could you mean the Sword Saint's Disciple…?"

Unlike the other two, who stood there flustered, Gong Ilhyuk's eyes flashed.

"As far as I know, that bastard is traveling with a scion of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"A scion of the Jin Family of Taiyuan? You mean that Jin Taekyung fellow you mentioned earlier?"

"Yes. He's half a day's journey from here."

The Roaring Fury Swordsman clicked his tongue.

“You cunning bastard. That’s why you came looking for this old man, isn’t it?”

“The name of the great Zhongnan Sect has fallen into the dirt because of these inept Disciples. Elder, aren’t you the person who cares about our sect more than anyone? I happened to hear that you were in the area on business, so…”

“Cut it out. From what you’ve told me, this Jin Taekyung fellow sounds like an incredibly arrogant bastard too.”

“That’s right. A bastard like him needs to be taught a harsh lesson.”

As if the thought had only just occurred to him, Gong Ilhyuk added,

“I hear the Jin Family of Taiyuan is holding a gathering.”

“A gathering?”

“They invited every sect in Shanxi Province so they could flaunt their power.”

“They trampled on our sect, and now they’re holding a gathering?”

Anger flared in the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s eyes.

“I’ve heard enough. Lead the way.”

“I obey, Elder.”

A smug smile spread across Gong Ilhyuk’s lips.

Chapter 185

“Baek Museong, First-generation Disciple of Huashan, pays his respects to his Martial Uncle.”

“Who are you?”

For a moment, I thought the world had stopped.

Jin Wikyung and Wolhwa, who had been walking behind Baek Museong, stopped in their tracks. Even the pretty young woman following them came to a halt.

Of course, Chulwoo had the best reaction of all.

“Senior Brother, what are you talking about? Why would our Martial Uncle be here?”

“Can’t you tell by looking?”

“Which Martial Uncle?”

“Martial Uncle Cheongpung. The man standing to your right.”

Chulwoo glanced at Cheongpung, then burst out laughing as if he’d just heard a fantastic joke.

“Ha ha ha! Senior Brother, you must be mistaken.”

“Second.”

“Enough. Wait, did you plan all this just to mess with me?”

“It’s the truth.”

“Senior Brother, I’m not that gullible. Now that I think about it, the people of the Jin Family of Taiyuan are quite the pranksters too. Did all of you really conspire just to fool me? Ha ha ha!”

“…”

What was this, some Korean-Chinese co-produced drama?

There was no way Huashan and the Jin Family of Taiyuan had joined forces to stage some hilarious hidden-camera prank just to fool this one guy.

“Ha ha ha.”

When no one—not even me—reacted, Chulwoo’s laughter gradually dwindled, then stopped altogether.

“…You’re serious?”

Baek Museong rubbed his temple as he answered.

“Yes.”

“Not a single word of it is a lie?”

“I told you, it’s true.”

Chulwoo whipped his head toward Cheongpung.

“Excuse me, Young Hero. What’s your name?”

“Cheongpung.”

Chulwoo's pupils trembled. He'd clearly remembered what he'd said to Cheongpung only moments ago.

"D-Dumpling."

"Dumpling?"

"N-Nothing. Then is this really Martial Uncle Cheongpung?"

"Without a doubt."

I almost wished I had some popcorn.

Leaving Chulwoo to slap his own cheeks over and over as if wondering whether he was dreaming, Baek Museong spoke.

"I apologize, Martial Uncle Cheongpung."

Cheongpung answered with an innocent expression.

"No, it's fine."

"You failed to recognize an elder of our sect and showed him grave disrespect. You ought to apologize a hundred times over. Is that not so?"

"Please forgive me, Martial Uncle."

Chulwoo bowed his head gloomily. Judging by his expression, he would need some time to accept that the dumpling ghost was his Martial Uncle.

Of course, Cheongpung didn't care in the slightest.

If anything, he was more curious about his relationship with these new faces.

"But who are all of you?"

"We are all Disciples of Huashan, just like Martial Uncle Cheongpung."

"Oh. But I'm just Grandpa's grandson."

The Sword Saint hadn't merely passed his martial arts on to Cheongpung as a Disciple. He had raised him as his grandson. That was why Cheongpung had only the vaguest understanding of sects and martial artists.

Yet even at that response, Baek Museong's gentle smile never faltered.

"My Master goes by the title of Heavenly Sword True Person. In terms of seniority, he is your eldest Senior Brother."

"My eldest Senior Brother?"

"Yes. Your Master—or rather, your grandfather—the Sword Saint had three Disciples before you. Have you ever heard about them?"

Cheongpung murmured uncertainly.

"I don't really know. I think Grandpa mentioned them once, but…"

"He even came to visit you with several others ten years ago."

Cheongpung thought hard, then suddenly exclaimed,

"Ah! That scary-looking old man!"

He'd just called the Sect Leader of Huashan a scary-looking old man. Regardless of everyone else's shock, Cheongpung beamed now that the mystery had been solved.

“He’s my eldest Senior Brother?”

“Precisely.”

“Ohhh. I see. I thought he was a bad person. It looked like he was trying to kick Grandpa and me out.”

“You may be unfamiliar with the circumstances of our sect, Martial Uncle. You can learn about those things little by little.”

What admirable patience.

Even if Baek Museong had slapped Cheongpung across the ear in the middle of their conversation, he probably would’ve been acquitted at the first trial. Yet his smile never faltered.

No wonder there’s a crane in his epithet.

As I was thinking that, Cheongpung turned to me with a bright smile.

“Benefactor, they say they’re my Martial Nephews!”

“Ah, yes. Congratulations.”

“Do you want to be my Martial Nephew too, Benefactor?”

“…Me?”

“Why? If you don’t want to be my Martial Nephew, I can make you my Martial Uncle.”

This crazy bastard was spouting nonsense.

Not only was that not something Cheongpung could decide on his own, but becoming Cheongpung’s Martial Uncle would make me a junior fellow Disciple of the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak.

For all I knew, I could even order the Sect Leader of Huashan to run cigarette errands for me.

“…”

That actually sounded pretty good.

I was about to nod as if under a spell when—

“Ha ha. Young Hero Cheongpung certainly knows how to tell a joke.”

Wipeng’s mouth was smiling, but his eyes said something entirely different.

His murderous glare snapped me back to my senses.

“No, it’s fine. I’m all right.”

“Really? What a shame.”

The other two members of the Three Plum Blossom Elites stood with their mouths hanging open in disbelief, but Baek Museong merely smiled.

“You may not be able to formally enter the sect, but we can certainly welcome you as an honored guest.”

I blinked.

“Was that a formal invitation?”

“Of course. An exceptional young prodigy like Young Hero Jin is always welcome. And…”

His gentle voice continued.

“You could also keep Martial Uncle Cheongpung company on his journey back to our sect.”

Cheongpung, who had been bouncing excitedly, went still.

“Huh? Go back?”

“Yes, Martial Uncle Cheongpung.”

Baek Museong offered a deep fist-and-palm salute. When he spoke again, his voice was stern and solemn.

“It is the Sect Leader’s order. Please return to Huashan.”

Watching Cheongpung disappear into the main hall of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Chulwoo clicked his tongue.

“What kind of man—or rather, Martial Uncle—is he?”

Even Eunhyang, who bickered with Chulwoo at every opportunity, nodded this time.

“Exactly. I didn’t know anyone could refuse our Master’s order.”

“There is one person. Grandmaster.”

“Senior Brother Chul, he doesn’t count.”

Chulwoo scratched the back of his head awkwardly.

“Well, that’s true.”

The Sect Leader’s authority was absolute. Even someone who outranked him in sect seniority couldn’t openly refuse his orders.

Challenging the Sect Leader’s authority was tantamount to tarnishing the sect’s name.

The larger the sect, the more rigidly that hierarchy was enforced.

“But to refuse him flat-out… Whew. I knew he was unusual, but he’s even more extraordinary than I expected.”

“You’ve only seen a tiny fraction of it. Earlier, I even called him Dumpling—no, never mind.”

Chulwoo shook his head, then cautiously asked,

“What are you planning to do now, Senior Brother?”

“I’m not sure.”

Baek Museong, who had been lost in thought, finally spoke.

“I didn’t expect Martial Uncle Cheongpung to refuse so stubbornly.”

“At this point, shouldn’t the Disciplinary Hall step in instead of us?”

“Why do you think so?”

“He disobeyed our Master’s order.”

Even the slightest violation of Huashan’s rules resulted in a summons from the Disciplinary Hall. If the Disciplinary Hall, which dealt with every infraction without mercy, passed judgment, Cheongpung would be treated as a serious criminal.

Seeing his Junior Brother huff indignantly, Baek Museong let out a quiet laugh.

“Martial Uncle did not violate the rules.”

“Pardon?”

“What do you mean?”

“The rules apply only to Disciples of our sect. Would a Disciple of Qingcheng Sect be punished for violating Shaolin’s rules?”

“Does that make any sense?”

“Of course it does. But Martial Uncle Cheongpung is… our Martial Uncle. He’s Grandmaster’s Disciple.”

“If only that were truly the case.”

Baek Museong added with a sigh,

“Strictly speaking, Martial Uncle Cheongpung is little different from an outsider. This happened because he never underwent the initiation ceremony.”

Everyone underwent an initiation ceremony, whether they were a main-sect Disciple or a lay Disciple. Only then did they officially become a Disciple of Huashan and have their name entered into the sect registry.

But Cheongpung was different.

“Who could have known Grandmaster would do something like that?”

Baek Museong remembered what had happened ten years ago with perfect clarity.

After the Sword Saint had lived in seclusion for many years, his Master, the Heavenly Sword True Person, had led several people in searching Huashan himself. At last, they discovered a residence where a ten-year-old boy was swinging a sword.

“It was unbelievable.”

No one knew when the boy had arrived, where he’d come from, or how he’d been raised. Yet he had already learned Huashan’s supreme secret arts.

But even the boy’s astonishing accomplishments were soon overshadowed by the Sword Saint’s even more astonishing words.

“You want me to initiate him?”

“Yes, Master. I intend to conduct the initiation ceremony and accept him as a main-sect Disciple. The order may be backward, but we cannot ignore a once-in-a-millennium genius like him—”

“Ignore him.”

"Pardon?"

"I said to continue ignoring him. When the time comes, I'll send him over myself."

"M-Master!"

"And don't come looking for him again. Not unless you want me to burn this whole place down."

"Set fire to Huashan? Are you saying we should all die together?"

"Oh. Now that you mention it, I suppose we would. Anyway, that's how it is. I'll take care of Cheongpung."

Chulwoo and Eunhyang both gaped at him.

"D-Did he really say that?"

"Are you sure you're not exaggerating?"

"I wish I were… but you both know what happened afterward."

Cheongpung, whom the Sword Saint had promised to send when the time was right, had slipped out into the world without anyone noticing, while the Sword Saint himself had vanished without a trace.

"The truth is, our Master isn't worried about Grandmaster. He's worried about Martial Uncle Cheongpung."

Cheongpung had already displayed unbelievable accomplishments ten years ago. But the world—and Murim in particular—overflowed with schemes and treachery.

It was far too dangerous for someone who wasn't a Disciple of Huashan to wander the world while possessing Huashan's secret arts.

"We must bring Martial Uncle Cheongpung back. For his sake, and for the sake of our sect. Do you understand?"

The two nodded at his resolute tone, then suddenly spoke up.

"But, Senior Brother…"

"How are we supposed to bring him back? By force?"

"That…"

Baek Museong hesitated before letting out a deep sigh.

"First, we need to bring the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi over to our side."

All three of them remembered Cheongpung's final words at the same time.

"I'm staying with my Benefactor!"

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung.

This unexpected obstacle made Baek Museong's head throb.

What did he do for Martial Uncle to call him his Benefactor? Did he save his life or something?

[1020] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered hawthorn fruit in hardened sugar.

A bond that had begun with a few candied hawthorn skewers[1020] was proving far more tenacious than expected.

The moment we entered the main hall, Wipeng demanded,

“What on earth did you do?”

“What do you mean?”

“I’m talking about Cheongpung.”

Everyone’s gaze naturally turned toward Cheongpung.

He was cramming the refreshments from the table into his mouth until his cheeks bulged.

“I didn’t really do anything.”

“Cheongpung defied the Sect Leader’s order. He said he would stay with the Third Young Master.”

“So?”

“What do you mean, ‘so’? Don’t you understand that one wrong move could strain the relationship between our family and Huashan?”

Was this like a parent blaming his top-student son’s friend when the boy’s grades dropped?

I shrugged.

“I’ll try to persuade him.”

“You must. You absolutely must persuade him.”

Wipeng’s voice rang with firm resolve. He whipped his head toward Jin Wikyung, who sat in the place of honor.

“My lord, please say something as well.”

“Very well.”

Jin Wikyung put on a solemn expression and spoke.

“My youngest. Your face has grown so haggard in just a few days. Was the journey uncomfortable? Do you have any idea how worried I was…?”

“Stop. I was insane to trust you, my lord.”

“Don’t be so hard on him. My youngest will take care of it.”

“This is driving me mad. As of today, I’m leaving the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Ha ha ha. You certainly know how to tell a joke.”

“Did that sound like a joke?”

“Yes. It was very funny.”

“I’m not amused. I haven’t been amused since the Third Young Master failed to return by noon yesterday as promised.”

Jin Wikyung’s eyes widened.

“Oh, that reminds me, my youngest.”

“As you promised last time, please give him a thorough scolding.”

“What’s that sword strapped to your back? It looks like you had it made while you were away. Let me see it.”

Unable to contain his anger, Wipeng shot to his feet.

“I’m really leaving. It’s been awful knowing you. Let’s never meet again.”

“Ha ha ha. What’s gotten into him today? Why does he keep making me laugh?”

“Damn it. Draw your sword.”

“Taekyung, Wipeng seems eager to see your new sword. Why don’t you draw it for him?”

“Aaaaaah!”

With his eyes rolling back, Wipeng let out a shriek and placed his hand on the sword hilt.

But my next words froze him in place.

“Since the Fire King gave it to me, I think it would be best not to touch it if possible.”

“…?”

“…?”

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng blinked silently before finally managing to speak.

“F-Fire what?”

“Third Young Master, what nonsense did you just say?”

“The Fire King. Fire King. He left a sword in my care. Oh, and a martial arts manual too.”

Thunk. Clang.

In the suffocating silence, the sound of Wipeng dropping his sword rang out like thunder.

Chapter 186

Jin Wikyung and Wipeng.

The longer my story went on, the more openly their emotions showed.

Shock. Disbelief. Then shock all over again.

“Th-That’s really true?”

I’d been talking for so long that I was exhausted.

“It’s one hundred percent pure truth. Believe me.”

Wipeng, who had been sitting there in a daze, suddenly lunged at me.

“Third Young Master, if any of this is a lie, I swear one of us is going to die—and then the other one will too.”

“I told you, it’s one hundred percent true. One hundred percent!”

“No, but still…”

“Not a single speck of falsehood. One hundred fucking percent!”

“…”

Wipeng faltered, his face saying, *Why do I suddenly feel so dirty?*

I waved the sword and martial arts manual at him.

The last thing I could do was give him time to think it over.

“If you still don’t believe me, inspect them yourself. The Flame Divine Palm manual and a sword made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron!”

“Gasp! Put those away. Now!”

A vampire wouldn’t have reacted that strongly to a cross shoved in its face.

“What’s wrong?”

Wipeng stared at me in horror.

“You’re telling me to inspect the Flame Divine Palm manual? Are you trying to get our entire family wiped out?”

“Oh, right. There was that.”

Anyone who stole a look at the Fire King’s signature martial art would get a taste of the heat—enough to set their entire body on fire.

“Anyway, it’s all true. There are witnesses right here. Isn’t that right?”

Hyuk Mujin, who had been sitting in the corner like a corpse, cautiously raised his hand.

“Forgive me for speaking out of turn, but it is all true.”

Cheongpung, busy cramming some unidentifiable snack into his mouth, spoke with a solemn expression.

“Uh-oh-wa-uh-oh!”

“…”

I doubted that testimony would carry much weight. More importantly, how long was that bastard planning to keep eating? Was his stomach some kind of bottomless jar?

"Wipeng, it seems Taekyung is telling the truth."

At Jin Wikyung's words, Wipeng nodded, his expression complicated.

"Yes. As difficult as it is to believe… I don't see how we can doubt him."

"The Fire King. The Fire King himself…"

Jin Wikyung let out a long breath. After a moment's hesitation, he picked up the Unnamed Sword from the table.

Shing.

A pure-white blade slid free of its rough scabbard.

As Jin Wikyung studied the frost-sharp edge, he murmured, "It smells of blood."

I had almost forgotten.

Before he was the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Jin Wikyung was a swordsman.

Without needing an Item description window like I did, he had accurately read the weapon's condition. He slid the sword back into its scabbard.

"Taekyung."

"Yes."

I straightened.

If Jin Wikyung called me Taekyung instead of *my youngest*, it meant he was about to say something serious.

"Do you know what these objects are?"

"Precious treasures, aren't they? The kind that would be difficult to obtain even for a thousand pieces of gold."

A Supreme Peak martial art with the power to dominate the world and a peerless sword forged from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

The Murim martial artists I knew would risk their lives to obtain these things.

Jin Wikyung shook his head.

"Wrong."

"What?"

"These are ghostly objects. They take away a person's soul and drive them mad."

"Oh."

"Do you know the name of that ghost?"

I muttered the answer.

"Greed."

"Yes. Greed. A tenacious, dangerous creature that dwells in every human heart."

I knew.

I had experienced it myself. How could I not know?

On that day several years ago, greed had taken root in my heart, and because of it, I had lost people close to me.

“I don’t know why the Fire King entrusted such dangerous objects to you, but… everything concerning them must be kept absolutely secret. Do you understand?”

His eyes and posture were directed solely at me, but the warning was meant for everyone in the room.

Me, Hyuk Mujin, and finally Cheongpung.

As though we had made a promise, we answered at the same time.

“Yes.”

“I’ll keep that in mind, Lesser Family Head.”

“Ah-uh-ah-hae-ho, ma-ah-hae-oh.”

…

That damn mouth of his. I ought to just—

Jin Wikyung drew back the heavy curtain. Through the lattice window, he watched Jin Taekyung’s retreating figure.

Sunlight struck the rough scabbard strapped across Taekyung’s back and shattered into fragments.

“The weather is fucking beautiful.”

“Didn’t you say it was fantastic earlier?”

“That was then. They mean nearly the same thing anyway.”

“This one sounds rather different.”

“Don’t nitpick when you know perfectly well what I mean. Come to think of it, why are you still here when you said you were leaving?”

Wipeng answered wearily.

“Don’t you start nitpicking either, my lord. My thoughts are tangled enough already.”

The same could be said for both of them.

Looking as if he had aged ten years, Jin Wikyung muttered, “What in the world is going on?”

“I would like to know that myself.”

Looking back on everything that had happened to the Jin Family of Taiyuan over the past year—no, barely half a year—it was enough to make a man wonder if some demon had descended upon them.

“After everything else, now the Fire King has appeared.”

"I hear he is extraordinarily eccentric. I'm worried his wrath may fall upon our family."

"Then we'll have to turn that danger into an opportunity."

Jin Wikyung ran his fingers over his teacup. To anyone watching, he would have appeared lost in thought, but his lips were moving almost imperceptibly.

How is that matter progressing?

Recognizing the Sound Transmission, Wipeng played along naturally.

"The tea has gone cold. Shall I have them bring you another cup?"

We haven't discovered anything yet.

"It's fine. This is still drinkable."

What about the surviving remnants?

"You'll ruin your health if you keep doing that."

Most of them died during the interrogation.

"You're the only one who worries about my health."

How many remain?

"Shouldn't I at least look after you, with the Lady of the House not here?"

Three.

Jin Wikyung's fingers went still.

The news was so unexpected that, for a moment, he forgot to continue the spoken conversation.

Only three?

Wipeng sighed and nodded.

They had a far more powerful restriction placed on them than expected. I'm sorry to say this, but… my abilities aren't enough.

It isn't your fault. Our family simply lacks the necessary capabilities.

Give me your orders.

Jin Wikyung's throat went dry.

Stop the interrogations. Keep them alive by any means necessary. For now, those men are our only physical evidence.

As you command.

Jin Wikyung closed his hand around the cold teacup.

The trembling surface of the tea reflected a distorted, featureless face.

Just like them.

Dark Heaven…

He didn't know where, how, or why they had done such a thing.

He was flailing at empty air without learning a single thing.

Yet one suspicion in Jin Wikyung's mind was steadily hardening into certainty.

They are extremely dangerous. Targeting Shanxi Province was only the beginning.

The Head Elder had endured for years, biding his time. Yet the outcome was far too paltry for a grand design decades in the making.

Jin Wikyung had realized that only after the thrill of victory faded.

This was… too easy.

It had been the perfect opportunity to seize an entire province.

Yet Dark Heaven had never shown themselves, as though this alone had been enough for them.

What in the world are they after?

For now, there was no way to know.

He could only hope he had overestimated them.

"My lord?"

"Ah."

"You've been away from your seat for too long. The guests are waiting."

"…Is that so?"

At Wipeng's prompting, Jin Wikyung drained his teacup in one gulp and rose.

"Let's go."

The gathering was for the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

For now, they could allow themselves to savor the joy of victory.

Winter days were short. I had only just returned to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, but the sun was already beginning to set.

Come to think of it, I haven't trained properly in days. Not unless circulating my qi counts.

I was loosening up by practicing martial arts in the training ground attached to my pavilion when some unexpected guests arrived.

"Benefactor!"

"Benefactor!"

"…?"

What was that, an echo?

I turned toward the voices.

"I'm here!"

Cheongpung was smiling brightly, his mouth covered in a thick layer of some mysterious sauce. And then there was…

"Benefactor! It's me, Socheon!"

"It has been a while, Young Hero Jin."

"Huh?"

They were Gong Yacheong and Socheon, survivors of the Sakju Branch.

A sudden rush of happiness swept over me at the sight of those familiar faces.

It feels like someone's missing, though.

As I tilted my head, a whining voice rose from below the stone wall blocking my view.

"Me too! Soyul wants to see Uncle too!"

"Wait a moment."

Gong Yacheong bent down, scooped something up, and hoisted it onto his shoulders.

It was Soyul. The little girl beamed and waved at me.

"Uncle!"

"Oh, you've grown a lot."

"You've grown a lot too, Uncle!"

"Thanks. But I'm not an uncle."

"Anyone can tell you're an uncle!"

"…Right."

What did it matter whether I was an uncle or not?

Chuckling, I walked over to them.

"Has everyone been well?"

Gong Yacheong answered with a faint smile.

"Of course."

He still looked somewhat gaunt, but there was color in his face. He was clearly doing far better than when he had been poisoned and hovering at death's door.

The kids seem to be doing well too.

Socheon was at the age when children shot up, and he had grown another half a handspan[1021] since I'd last seen him. Soyul's cheeks were nice and plump.

And Cheongpung's stomach had swollen into a round little belly from all the food he'd eaten.

"…"

Right. Eat well and grow big.

Twenty was still a growing age, after all.

"What brings all of you here?"

Socheon answered as though he'd been waiting for me to ask.

"Martial Artist Hyuk requested it. The banquet is about to begin, but he has to report for guard duty, so he asked us to deliver the message in his place."

"Oh, the banquet."

[1021] A handspan, or *ppyeom*, is measured between an outstretched thumb and little finger. Its length varies by person; half a handspan is roughly 10 cm (4 in).

I vaguely remembered hearing about it earlier. There was supposed to be a grand banquet that evening.

Cheongpung, who had been licking the sauce from around his mouth, suddenly looked shocked.

“Gasp! Really?”

“…What? Didn’t you come here because you already knew?”

“No. If I’d known, I would’ve eaten less!”

Soyul also opened her eyes wide in shock. The candied treat in her hand slipped to the ground.

“No! Soyul’s full too!”

“…”

From their reactions, I could make a pretty good guess where the two of them had met.

“So, when does it start?”

“Less than half an hour from now, Benefactor.”

“Benefactor, hurry! I’ve never been to a banquet before!”

“Where is it?”

“In front of the new Grand Training Ground, Benefactor.”

“They said it’s in front of the Grand Training Ground, Benefactor!”

“Oh, there.”

I set down the practice spear in my hand and firmly secured the bundle beside me across my back.

The bundle, of course, contained the sword entrusted to me by the Fire King.

“Let’s all go.”

I started walking, only to stop short. I’d just remembered something I’d been meaning to say.

“Oh, and one more thing…”

“Please speak, Benefactor.”

“What is it, Benefactor?”

I heaved a deep sigh.

“Only one of you should call me Benefactor. It’s confusing.”

They were like a pair of parrots.

Without taking even a second to think, the two Benefactor parrots nodded.

“I’ll remember that, Benefactor.”

“Okay, Benefactor.”

“…”

No, think before you answer.

The Grand Training Ground.

True to its name, it was the largest training ground in the family, and it was packed shoulder to shoulder with people.

“What the hell? Why are there so many?”

I thought only invited guests were allowed in.

Cheongpung answered my question.

“I heard from the cook earlier that the Lesser Family Head said everyone should celebrate together on such a wonderful day, so he ordered them to let in all the people waiting outside too.”

“All of them?”

“Yes. The cook got really angry. He said the Lesser Family Head didn’t have any sense and shouldn’t run his mouth when he wasn’t going to help with the cooking.”

Soyul, happily sucking on a candied treat, chimed in.

“That’s right! He even gave Soyul a candied treat and told her not to tell anyone!”

“…Then why are you telling us?”

“Gasp!”

I shook my head and kept walking.

Before I had gone more than a few steps, a martial artist from the Jin Family approached.

“We will escort the two Young Masters to their seats.”

“I don’t mind watching from anywhere. I suppose that isn’t allowed?”

“No, Young Master. It is the Lesser Family Head’s order.”

Given the occasion, there was no helping it.

I exchanged brief farewells with Gong Yacheong and the others, then followed the martial artist to the seat prepared for me.

Mine was one of the places of honor reserved for a select few distinguished guests.

Which, of course, meant…

“Martial Uncle Cheongpung, Young Master Jin. We meet again so soon.”

The Three Plum Blossom Elites were among them.

Baek Museong had his junior disciples seated on either side of him. He greeted us with a fairly friendly expression.

“We didn’t get a proper chance to introduce ourselves earlier, did we? I’m Eunhyang.”

SYSTEM

Level: 75
Eunhyang

She was probably around the same age as my younger sister, Hayeon.
No sooner had I finished greeting her than a sullen voice cut in.
“Damn it. You’re sitting next to me?”
It was Chulwoo, a massive man whose bulk made the seat itself look cramped.
“Why? Don’t like it?”
“Would you?”
“I don’t like it either. That’s why I said it. Guess we agree on something.”
“Don’t say something so disgusting!”
“Then switch seats.”
“With whom?”
“Lots of people besides you would love to sit there. Switch with anyone standing down below.”
“You son of a bitch!”
“Did you just insult my parents? In the Jin Family of Taiyuan? Are you trying to pull a Jin-rula here?”
Chulwoo trembled with rage, but Baek Museong immediately rebuked him.
“You fool! What kind of outrageous language is that?”
“No, Senior Brother. It’s just…”
“Quiet. Young Hero Jin, I apologize on behalf of my Junior Brother. I also offer my apologies to Martial Uncle Cheongpung.”
Cheongpung, who had been hiding behind me, cautiously poked his head out.
“I’m fine, Martial Nephew.”
I smiled gently as well.
“I’m fine too. His blood is bound to run hot at that age. We should be understanding.”
“You’re five years younger than me, you little punk! What did you just say?”
“Young Hero Baek, if it isn’t too much trouble, could you switch seats with me? I’m a little afraid to sit beside him…”
“Second!”
“Whoo. Whoo-hoo.”
I dropped into the seat beside the snorting Chulwoo.
Chulwoo to my right, Cheongpung to my left.
What a spectacular arrangement.
Where is Jin Wikyung?

I looked around, but there was no sign of Jin Wikyung or Wipeng.

Then—

Boom!

The martial artists of the Jin Family surrounding the Grand Training Ground began striking their weapons.

There were more than three hundred of them. A blade-sharp aura and wave-like spirit surged from their ranks.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Like drums pounding across a battlefield, the sound grew louder and louder until it swallowed every other noise.

And then…

BOOM!

With the loudest thunderclap yet, the human curtain split apart.

Chapter 187

Hundreds of martial artists stood there, radiating an aura as sharp as frost. Along the path they had opened, one man approached.

Step. Step.

The commoners who had come to watch, the nameless martial artists dressed in worn uniforms, and finally the powerful figures who moved Shanxi Province—

Everyone held their breath and watched that one man.

Jin Wikyung.

This is like something out of a movie.

Clad in a martial uniform embroidered with a silver wyvern, Jin Wikyung strode forward without hesitation. His commanding presence and effortless authority overwhelmed everyone present.

The silence Jin Wikyung had created was broken by his voice.

“Our family first put down roots in Taiyuan three hundred years ago.”

His shout, infused with profound internal energy, carried far and wide.

“Our beginnings were undeniably humble.”

It had been an age of chaos. Natural disasters struck one after another, and the empire that had seemed eternal lost its strength. Warlords raised their banners throughout the land and declared themselves kings, plunging the realm into war.

Blood instead of water soaked the parched earth, while grain waiting to be harvested was trampled beneath horses’ hooves.

At the end of that long war, a man who had wandered the realm stopped in the ruined capital of an old dynasty.

That was the beginning of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“Our ancestor, Grand Patriarch Jin Muryang, took in orphans and cared for widows and the elderly. Though he raised the banner of martial strength, he never forgot humanity.”

The small seed soon sprouted. Those who gathered beneath the banner of the Jin Family of Taiyuan became its branches, its trunk, and its strong, deep roots.

The family that had begun so humbly grew into a towering tree whose reach extended across all of Shanxi Province.

“Yet even our family could not escape the rise and fall of fortune.”

Everything had slowly changed with the passage of time. After enduring one event after another, both great and small, the towering tree began to wither.

Mistaken decisions by its leaders, invasions by foreign enemies, betrayals by allies, natural disasters beyond human power to prevent…

Before long, its many branches had broken and its lush leaves had fallen.

“But!”

A thunderous shout burst forth. His voice boiled like lava.

“We survived.”

Though the branches broke and the leaves fell, the roots remained whole.

“We may have been shaken, but we were never uprooted.”

As long as the roots remained, the tree would grow again. It would regain its vitality and put forth lush new leaves as though nothing had ever happened.

Just as it was doing now.

“As the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, I swear this.”

Boom!

Hundreds of weapons struck the ground. Invisible heat rose from the martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan as they dropped to one knee.

“We! The Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

It was a vow to the family’s countless members, to everyone gathered here, and to the enemies who had yet to bare their fangs.

“Three hundred years ago and three hundred years from now, we will remain here unchanged!”

Boom! Boom!

“I ask you all!”

His blazing eyes swept across the crowd. Taking in faces filled with excitement and anticipation, fear and guilt, Jin Wikyung shouted,

“Are you ready to lay a new foundation alongside our family?”

A tremendous roar erupted from the crowd, centered on the martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“Loyalty!”

Boom, boom-boom-boom-boom-boom!

Just then, a clear voice rang out from somewhere.

“May we also join the Jin Family of Taiyuan on the path it has chosen?”

The voice had come neither from the place of honor where I sat nor from the seats reserved for distinguished guests below.

The vast crowd surrounding the Grand Training Ground parted, revealing the owner of the voice.

That’s…

Instead of a flowing court dress, she wore a comfortable martial uniform. With features mature beyond her years, she respectfully saluted Jin Wikyung with clasped fists.

“I am Lee Seowol of the Mount Heng Sword Sect. I have arrived in response to the Lesser Family Head’s summons.”

The middle-aged man who had been standing beside her like an iron tower revealed his identity in a rough voice.

“I am First Elder Cheol Mubaek. I pay my respects to the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

The martial artists of the Mount Heng Sword Sect standing behind them shouted in unison.

“We pay our respects to the Lesser Family Head!”

A stir swept through the crowd.

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had appeared when it stood on the very brink of destruction.

Its new Sect Leader was the late Blood Wolf Sword’s only daughter, while the man at her side who called himself First Elder was Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng.

Yet amid everyone else’s astonishment, Jin Wikyung remained perfectly calm.

Of course he did. He was the one who had sent me to deliver their invitation for New Year’s Day.

“This is the first time I’ve met you in person, Young Lady. Did you receive the formal invitation I sent last time?”

“Yes. And in addition…”

Lee Seowol answered calmly, then raised her head and looked in my direction.

“I received a kindness I could never hope to repay.”

Every gaze that swung my way made my face prickle.

Naturally. There probably wasn’t a single person in Shanxi Province who didn’t know that Jin Mukyung and I had saved the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

After giving me a faint smile, she turned back to Jin Wikyung.

“I would like to hear your answer to the question I asked earlier.”

Lee Seowol drew a deep breath. Her eyelids trembled.

“May we… join the Jin Family of Taiyuan as well?”

Jin Wikyung answered without a moment’s hesitation.

“Of course.”

“…!”

“Now it is my turn to ask. Are you prepared to walk alongside our family?”

Thump.

Instead of answering, Lee Seowol dropped to one knee. Cheol Mubaek and the martial artists under his command did the same.

“I, Lee Seowol, second Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, swear before Heaven and Earth.”

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had once commanded Shanxi Murim. Now its new Sect Leader, inheritor of its orthodox lineage, knelt before Jin Wikyung.

No. She knelt before the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“Our sect pledges its loyalty to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

"Loyalty!"

They were few in number, but their shout was thunderous. Jin Wikyung took Lee Seowol by the shoulder and helped her to her feet.

His manner of speech had shifted naturally as well.

"I grant you permission."

On the first day of the new year, the Jin Family of Taiyuan accepted the Mount Heng Sword Sect as its vassal.

"Waaaaaaah!"

"Jin Family of Taiyuan! Jin Family of Taiyuan!"

Cheers upon cheers.

The crowd of more than a thousand people enthusiastically chanted the name of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

It really was that impressive.

First came a speech that set the listeners' blood boiling, followed by the Mount Heng Sword Sect's oath of loyalty.

What an ending.

The real banquet hadn't even begun, but everyone present must have realized it by now.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was the hegemon of Shanxi Province, possessed of both overwhelming power and mercy.

Chulwoo, seated beside me, was no exception.

"…Whoa."

The guy who had seemed simpleminded and proud to a fault now wore an expression of genuine admiration.

The kid knows a thing or two.

It was childish, but I couldn't help puffing out my chest a little. I was a member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, after all, and I'd contributed quite a bit to making this day possible.

"Ahem, ahem. Looks like you were moved."

"It was incredible. My heart pounded the entire time."

Chulwoo continued, his voice brimming with excitement.

"How can anyone be so beautiful?"

"Not to brag, but the Jin Family of Taiyuan has become a pretty big deal in Shanxi —what did you say?"

What had I just heard?

After some hesitation, I asked uneasily,

"You're not talking about my eldest brother, are you?"

"What?"

"You know, that sort of thing. *I covet that man's muscles. I want to do bench presses with him while we strip off each other's Under Armour*[1022]. Something like that…"

"What the hell are you talking about?"

Chulwoo frowned. Judging by his expression, that wasn't what he meant.

"Good. That's a relief. I thought you were gay."

"Gay? What's that?"

"Well, to put it metaphorically, I suppose it's the process by which a pair of Diglett[1023] meet and become Dugtrio[1024]."

"I can't understand a word you're saying. Explain it simply."

I came up with the simplest term possible.

"Male homosexuality."

"You little bastard…!"

Chulwoo was about to raise his fist when he stopped short. Baek Museong, his Senior Brother, was sitting right beside him.

The Huashan's Lone Crane buff was damn useful.

I grinned and asked,

"So who exactly is beautiful?"

"The woman! That woman from the Mount Heng Sword Sect!"

"Oh, Young Lady Lee Seowol?"

Strictly speaking, she was the Sect Leader, but calling her Young Lady still felt more natural.

At my familiar tone, Chulwoo's eyes lit up.

"Y-You know her?"

"We have a little history."

"What kind of history?"

A history that began with a sexual harassment scandal and ended with a marriage proposal, I suppose.

"It's a pain to explain. The whole story is pretty eventful. But don't tell me…"

I trailed off and looked at Chulwoo.

"You're interested in Young Lady Lee?"

"Interested?"

Chulwoo shot to his feet, and I felt slightly reassured.

[1022] Under Armour is an American sportswear brand.

[1023] Diglett is a small, single-headed Pokémon that emerges from the ground.

[1024] Dugtrio is a Pokémon depicted as three Diglett-like heads together.

"Right? You kept talking about your heart pounding, so I thought you were actually interested in—"

"This isn't interest! It's love."

"…"

"Three children should be about right. Two boys and one girl."

"…Sure. Keep going."

"We'll raise a yellow dog too. I heard that children who grow up with a dog develop better emotionally. We'll have a happy family."

I was about to call him an idiot when I suddenly stopped.

I feel like I've seen this scene before.

Where had I seen it?

For some reason, something about it hit a sore spot.

And why was I suddenly thinking about Song-i and Uncle Kkeokjeong back in the real world?

That's strange.

I pushed the question aside and spoke.

"Are you done?"

"I'm not done yet."

"Then let's pretend you are and listen to me. This is important."

My serious tone gave Chulwoo pause.

"Important?"

"Yeah. How old are you?"

"Twenty-five."

"Do you know how old Young Lady Lee is?"

"No."

"She's seventeen. Ah, the year just changed, so she's eighteen now."

"So?"

"What do you mean, so, you goddamn monster? Forget the seven-year age gap—she's still eating school lunches and doing late-night study sessions! She's only just choosing between humanities and sciences! What about her school grades?"

Chulwoo stared at me in bewilderment.

"What are you talking about? She's at the perfect age to marry."

"Ah, sorry. I got carried away."

As the older brother of a younger sister who was still in school, I couldn't help putting myself in her shoes. I kept forgetting this was Murim.

"Anyway, think it through. Don't let some fleeting emotion carry you away."

"No."

Chulwoo answered firmly, his expression turning dreamy.

“I knew the moment I saw her. My heart, which had lain still my entire life, finally began to beat.”

“…So you were dead for twenty-five years?”

“Dead? Yes, you’re right. Before I met her, I was little more than a corpse.”

“Can you really not die? Please die.”

“I can’t. Without her permission, I can neither die nor live.”

“…Wow. What a load of bullshit.”

Baek Museong and Eunhyang, who had been listening to our conversation, shook their heads.

“Here we go again.”

“Big Brother, didn’t you say something similar to that pretty third-generation Disciple last year?”

He’s a repeat offender?

What are you, some kind of serial confession demon?

Just as Chulwoo was about to explode at Eunhyang for exposing his embarrassing past—

“Young Master Jin.”

A lovely voice reached my ears. I turned and saw a woman climbing the stairs.

No. A girl.

Lee Seowol.

It was her.

Chapter 188

Dressed in a martial uniform, she looked more mature—and more beautiful—than the last time I'd seen her.

A faint fragrance drifted toward me as she drew closer.

Honestly, I can see why Chulwoo fell for her.

And not just Chulwoo. Half the men gathered at the Jin Family of Taiyuan were probably weighing their chances of confessing to her.

And a girl like that proposed to me.

She was still just a kid, and her proposal had been little more than an offer of political marriage, but I couldn't help feeling strange about it.

At last, she stopped in front of me and greeted me.

"It's good to see you again. Have you been well?"

"Yes. What about you, Young Lady Lee?"

The words had barely left my mouth when I realized my mistake. Her family had been killed, and her sect had nearly been annihilated. There was no way she could have been well.

"Uh…"

While I floundered, Lee Seowol answered.

"I've been well. Thanks to you, Young Master Jin."

With a light smile, she added,

"And I'll continue to be."

There was a steely resolve in her voice. It was as though the crisis that had nearly destroyed her sect, and the difficult decision to swear loyalty, had helped her grow.

I answered sincerely.

"I hope so."

Lee Seowol gave me a faint smile and nodded. That was when—

"H-Hey, Taekyung!"

"…What are you doing?"

I stared at Chulwoo in disbelief. He had thrown an arm around my shoulders, his expression and tone painfully awkward.

"You're in the way. Get your arm off me."

"H-Hahahaha! What's gotten into you? We're childhood friends. What's a little thing like this between us?"

"Weren't we sworn enemies?"

"M-My friend, your jokes have improved tremendously! Hwa-ha, hahahaha!"

"Does that sound like a joke to you?"

"Ah! By the way, who might this beautiful lady be?"

"…So that's what this was about."

The fabric of space-time cringed. Having flawlessly delivered the worst performance imaginable, Chulwoo bowed ninety degrees to Lee Seowol.

"Hello! It is an honor to meet you!"

"Ah… yes. It's an honor to meet you too."

"If I may introduce myself, I am this man's friend of ten years—"

To help the flustered Lee Seowol, I added,

"We met for the first time today."

"Although we only met today, we have already forged a bond worthy of friends of ten years—"

"We're not close at all."

"S-Since fate has brought us together, perhaps you'd care to sit beside me—"

"He's hitting on you because he thinks you're pretty. Don't fall for it."

Chulwoo ground his teeth. Lee Seowol's eyes widened.

"Oh, really?"

"Yes. Can't you tell just by looking at him?"

There was such a thing as being too oblivious. If she couldn't pick up on something this obvious, she was in trouble.

I sighed, and Lee Seowol stepped closer.

"No. I meant the other thing."

"Pardon?"

"Do you think I'm pretty, too, Young Master Jin?"

"Wait. Hold on."

Her voice was alluring, and her eyes sparkled.

What's gotten into her? Why is she acting like this?

Chulwoo watched the two of us, his gaze sinking into gloomy despair.

"Waaaaah!"

"Drink! Drink!"

The atmosphere at the Grand Training Ground was incredible, to put it mildly. The dance troupe—or rather, the dancers—brought in from Honghwaru captivated everyone with their dazzling movements, while the crowd ate, drank, and made merry.

Even the honored guests, who had looked uncomfortable at first, began to relax.

Those bastards should be on their knees with their heads to the floor, and even that wouldn't be enough.

Many of the honored guests owed the Jin Family of Taiyuan a debt, yet they had remained neutral during the recent war.

Neutral was a generous way to put it. They had backed out because they feared retaliation from the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

They must feel safe now that we've accepted the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

In front of those very people, Jin Wikyung had embraced the Mount Heng Sword Sect, the Jin Family's greatest enemy, and seated Lee Seowol in a place of honor.

It meant he had no intention of holding them accountable for what had happened.

Naturally, the atmosphere among the honored guests warmed at once. Swift oaths of loyalty followed, along with a barrage of gifts.

"Lesser Family Head, the Sangdo Sect and I wish to cast our lot with the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Oh, how kind of you."

"This is a small gift I prepared as a token of my sincerity."

"Thank you, Sect Leader Hwang."

"Great Hero Jin, I lead the merchant guild…"

"It is a humble offering, but please accept it…"

It didn't take long for luxury goods, gold, and silver treasures to pile up like a mountain. I doubted Jin Wikyung would ever have to worry about the family budget again after today.

Once things had settled down, Jin Wikyung approached me.

"How was it?"

I gave him a thumbs-up.

"It was impressive. But is it really all right for you to come over already? It looks like some people haven't even had a chance to speak with you."

"That is precisely why they will grow anxious."

"What?"

"How do you think those who failed to speak with me today will feel?"

"I don't know. Like they've fallen far behind everyone else?"

"Correct."

Jin Wikyung took a sip of his drink and winked at me.

"The more desperate they become, the more they will offer. This is only the first day. I am looking forward to the final day even more."

"Damn."

He was going to bleed them dry.

The Sect Leaders of the Five Gates of Shanxi, who were staring this way as though someone had lit a fire under their asses, would undoubtedly be the highlight of the final day.

"But, my youngest."

Jin Wikyung lowered his voice.

“Why is the Defeated Flower Fist acting like that?”

At some point, Chulwoo had moved to the far end of the honored seats. He kept glancing our way with a gloomy expression.

He would glare at me with blazing eyes, then heave a deep sigh whenever Lee Seowol and I exchanged a few words.

“Uh, well…”

How was I supposed to explain this? Lee Seowol was sitting nearby, so I had to watch what I said.

If I’d known this would happen, I would’ve practiced Sound Transmission beforehand.

Reaching the Peak realm had made Sound Transmission available for me to acquire through practice. It hadn’t granted me the skill on the spot.

“He looks unwell. Is he hurt?”

He was probably hurting, all right. In his heart.

“I guess he’s just in a bad mood.”

I gave a vague answer. Just then, the music filling the Grand Training Ground abruptly stopped, and people began to murmur.

Who’s that now?

A young man strode confidently through the flustered dancers. After surveying his surroundings, he gave a respectful fist-and-palm salute toward the honored seats.

More precisely, toward Jin Wikyung.

“My name is Choo Dohwan of the Iron Blood Sect of Henan.”

Jin Wikyung’s eyes widened.

“Could you be Choo Dohwan, the Iron Fist?”

“It is merely an undeserved reputation.”

“I have heard much about you. But what brings a Disciple of the Iron Blood Sect here without prior notice?”

Even I had heard of the Iron Blood Sect of Henan a couple of times. It was a well-known sect.

Judging by his sect alone, he must rank among the top three honored guests here.

With everyone’s attention focused on him, Choo Dohwan revealed why he had stepped forward.

“I have come to request a duel.”

“A duel? Now?”

“Yes. I apologize for the imposition, but I ask that you grant my request.”

Of course he ought to apologize. What kind of occasion did he think this was?

Surprisingly, however, very few people frowned. Most had already had a few drinks and seemed to regard this as an exciting surprise event.

“Hmm.”

“If you refuse, I will offer a sincere apology and withdraw.”

At least he knew his manners. Baek Museong, who had been watching the exchange, added,

“I too have heard the name Choo Dohwan, the Iron Fist. They say that, as befits a Disciple of the Iron Blood Sect, he excels in fist-and-foot martial arts and is a man of upright character.”

“You could choose Baek Museong as your opponent.”

Baek Museong smiled faintly.

“My junior brothers and I would be happy to accept.”

“Are you certain?”

“Of course. On such a fine day, I can only be grateful for the chance to enliven the festivities as a guest.”

His answer carried both the composure of a powerful man and impeccable courtesy. Jin Wikyung rose from his seat.

“I accept Young Hero Choo’s request.”

“Thank you.”

But Jin Wikyung didn’t stop there.

“Furthermore, anyone who wishes to participate in the duels may step forward! The final victor will receive one hundred silver nyang[1025] and a fine weapon worthy of the prize!”

“Waaaaah!”

Cheers erupted at his generous gesture, rowing while the tide was coming in. After all, there was nothing more entertaining in the world than watching a fight.

The eyes of the young martial artists, still brimming with youthful vigor, lit up at the thought of testing themselves.

“Then, Young Hero Choo!”

Jin Wikyung drew everyone’s attention with his booming voice, then asked Choo Dohwan,

“Name your first opponent.”

“The opponent I wish to face is…”

A Disciple of the Iron Blood Sect, famous for his fist-and-foot martial arts. His epithet was the Iron Fist, for heaven’s sake.

It’s obvious.

Just as I expected, Choo Dohwan named a particular person.

“Chulwoo, the Defeated Flower Fist!”

“…Me?”

[1025] A nyang was a traditional Korean unit of currency; the prize here is stated in silver.

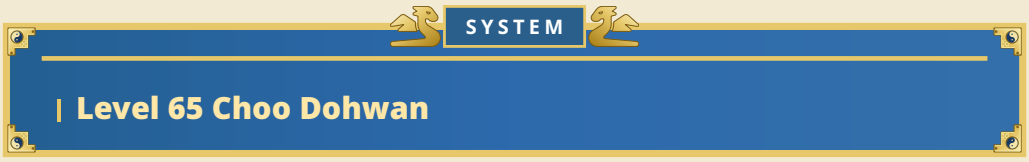
Chulwoo, who had been sitting there in a daze, rose to his full height. His gloom-soaked eyes settled on Choo Dohwan.

“Sounds good.”

“Let us determine which of us is stronger!”

I looked at the Level window floating over Choo Dohwan’s head and thought,

He’s going to get beaten to death.



And my prediction soon became reality.

Wham! Wham! Wham!

There were no forms or techniques involved. The difference between the Peak realm and First Rate was like the difference between heaven and earth, and Choo Dohwan had nothing that could bridge that gap.

Thud!

“Guh! H-How can it be this easy?”

“Are you really the Iron Fist? Why are you so soft?”

Chulwoo, meanwhile, rampaged like a monster. His martial arts were on a higher level, and he had been born with tremendous strength, size, and toughness. It took him only fifty exchanges to knock his opponent senseless.

And honestly, he seemed to have gone pretty easy on him.

“You know how to throw a punch, but it won’t work on me anyway. Give up here.”

Choo Dohwan gritted his teeth.

“No! It isn’t over until it’s over!”

“What a stubborn bastard.”

Whoosh! Crack! Thump!

Well, now it really was over.

Once Choo Dohwan lost consciousness, the waiting martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan brought over a stretcher and carried him away.

“Whaaaat?”

“As expected of the Defeated Flower Fist!”

“The Iron Fist Choo Dohwan is a fairly well-known master, but even he’s no match for one of Huashan’s Three Plum Blossom Elites.”

Under the simple rules they had established, the winner had to continue accepting challenges. If no challengers remained, the winner could name an opponent.

Lee Seowol, who had somehow claimed the seat beside me, whispered,

“Do you think anyone else will challenge him?”

I snorted quietly.

“After seeing what happened to the Iron Fist? Do you really think anyone will come forward? I’ll bet my wrist that nobody does.”

Just then, a man wearing a heroic headband suddenly stepped forward and shouted,

“I am Hwang Jinsu of Hwang Family Manor! I challenge the Defeated Flower Fist!”

“…”

“…”

Ah, shit. I should’ve kept my mouth shut.

Crack! Thud!

As I wallowed in regret, Hwang Jinsu of Hwang Family Manor collapsed, scattering teeth everywhere.

A Level 25 had stepped forward. Of course that was the result.

“What about now?”

“Didn’t you just see what happened? He got it even worse than the Iron Fist. Bones can be set, but teeth are finished. Completely finished.”

“And your wrist…”

“Fine, I’ll bet it. I bet my left wrist before, so this time it’s my right. Just watch. Nobody’s coming forward now. Seriously.”

A wandering martial artist in a bamboo hat stepped forward.

“I am Gal Mo. I may be a nameless wandering martial artist, but would you care to exchange a few moves?”

“No need to ask. Come on up.”

Did that bastard smear honey on his fists or something? Why do the challengers keep coming?

After knocking down fifteen or so people in about half an hour, Chulwoo roared,

“Is there no one who can stand against me?”

Despite fighting so many duels in such a short time, he was still bursting with energy. The difference in skill was so vast that even the other martial artists now looked thoroughly daunted.

Thinking this was my chance, I spoke up.

“Nobody’s coming out now. Really, nobody. I’ll bet my wrist.”

Lee Seowol helpfully replied,

“You already bet those earlier. Both of them.”

“Then my left ankle.”

“You bet that on the fifth match.”

“Oh, then what about my right ankle?”

“You already bet that on the sixth.”

“My neck…”

“The eighth match…”

Damn it. So this was what a corpse with its eyes open looked like.

As I sat there in a daze, Lee Seowol let out a small laugh.

“It’s all right. I won’t collect.”

“…Were you planning to?”

“If you do me one favor.”

“What favor?”

Just as Lee Seowol was about to open her mouth—

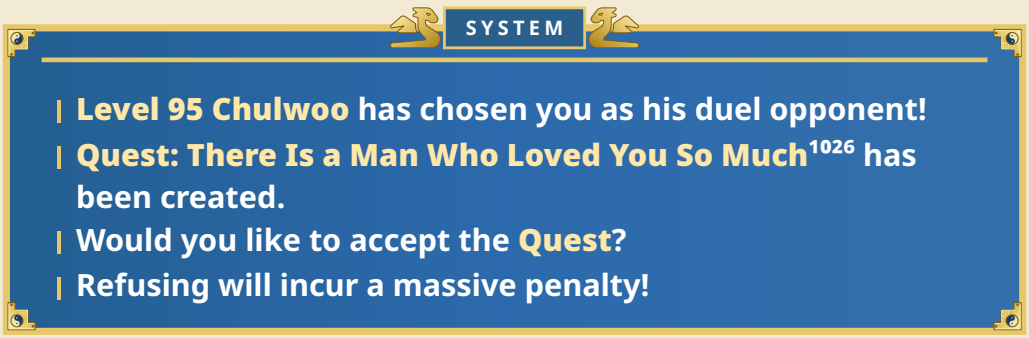
“Shan! Xi! Sleeping! Dragon!”

A tremendous shout shook the Grand Training Ground. Having defeated every challenger, Chulwoo stared at me and crooked a finger.

“Jin Taekyung, come out.”

At the same time, a System alert rang out.

Ding.



“…”

I could say this with absolute certainty: that was the most fucked-up quest title I had ever received.

[1026] The title echoes the opening line of “One Man,” a Korean ballad by Kim Jong-kook.

Chapter 189

SYSTEM

Quest
There Is a Man Who Loved You So Much
A man's burning love for a woman has manifested as jealousy and rage.
He seeks to win her love by defeating you.
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Task: Win the duel (Incomplete)
Reward: EXP and Fame
Failure: Acquire the Title Weak Male
—Would you like to accept the Quest?
—If you refuse the Quest, the Title Weak Male will be granted.

Wow. This is bullshit.

Of course, the penalty for refusing would suck twice as much.

Not like I have a choice.

I clicked my tongue and rose from my seat, drawing everyone's attention.

"Young Master Jin!"

"Young Master Jin."

"Young Hero Jin, you don't need to go out there."

"That's right. Has Senior Brother Chul gone crazy? Why is he suddenly acting like this?"

Wolhwa, Lee Seowol, Baek Museong, and even Eunhyang, whom I'd barely exchanged a few words with, all looked at me with concern.

I was the only one who didn't think much of it.

"It's fine. We'll have a good, clean fight."

Wolhwa sighed.

"Young Master Jin, do you know who you're up against?"

"Of course. Chulwoo, the Defeated Flower Fist."

"I don't think you do. The Defeated Flower Fist is considered a prodigy even within Huashan. Think carefully about why he's called one of the Three Plum Blossom Elites."

"Probably because he's good at fighting."

"No, that's not what I… Whew. Fine. I give up. Do whatever you want."

Wolhwa was out.

Baek Museong and Eunhyang stepped forward next.

“I don’t mean to underestimate Young Hero Jin, but my Second Junior Brother is, how should I put this? He’s…”

“A mad bull. When Senior Brother Chul loses his temper, dealing with him is a real nightmare.”

“Eunhyang!”

“What? I’m not wrong.”

In short, they were saying someone like me was no match for Chulwoo.

That’s what you think.

I thought otherwise. I still didn’t know whether it was arrogance or confidence. I just…

I don’t think I’ll lose.

I was certain of it. Certain that I could defeat the man shouting at me.

“Come! Out! Right! Now!”

“I’m coming, you bastard.”

With more than a thousand people gathered around the Grand Training Ground watching me, I walked toward Chulwoo.

“We must stop the duel.”

At Baek Museong’s words, Jin Wikyung shook his head.

“My younger brother has already accepted the Defeated Flower Fist’s challenge. The duel will end after that.”

“Great Hero Jin.”

“I don’t know what happened between them, but there seems to be some bad blood. Wouldn’t this be a good opportunity for them to clear the air?”

Baek Museong sighed inwardly at Jin Wikyung’s carefree response.

Does he not understand the situation?

From what Baek Museong could see, Chulwoo was absolutely furious. He looked ready to break several of Jin Taekyung’s limbs before he stopped.

This is bad.

They had to stop this now. Baek Museong had heard more than enough rumors about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi on the journey here, but in his eyes, Jin Taekyung was no match for his Second Junior Brother.

The names Defeated Flower Fist and Three Plum Blossom Elites had not been earned through his Master’s reputation alone.

“He could be seriously injured. Shouldn’t we intervene before something happens?”

"Who?"

"…Pardon?"

"The duel hasn't even begun yet. Nor has its outcome been decided."

Baek Museong realized he had been mistaken. Jin Wikyung understood the situation better than anyone.

They were simply operating under different assumptions.

"Great Hero Jin. Don't tell me…"

"That's right."

Jin Wikyung gave a low laugh. His gaze remained fixed on the back of his younger brother as he walked toward the dueling platform.

"That boy will win. Just as he always has."

"…"

Baek Museong was left speechless. The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi was undeniably a remarkable prodigy, but he couldn't match Chulwoo in experience, martial arts, or internal energy.

Baek Museong had watched Chulwoo since childhood. He could say that with absolute certainty.

The Lesser Family Head is wrong. The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi can't stand against my Second Junior Brother.

Baek Museong shook his head, but the water had already been spilled. If they backed down now, the prestige of both sects would be dragged through the dirt.

I'll have to intervene at the right moment.

As he watched the dueling platform with a grave expression, he overlooked one fact.

Munch, munch. Smack, smack.

Cheongpung—the man who called Jin Taekyung his Benefactor—was silently watching the situation unfold.

"Waaaaah!"

"Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi! Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!"

"Defeated Flower Fist! Defeated Flower Fist!"

The moment I stepped onto the dueling platform, cheers erupted from every direction. The response was on a completely different level from when the previous challengers had appeared.

"Oh, so everyone knows the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. Just so you know, he's. Damn. Strong."

"Waaaaah!"

As I enthusiastically waved to the crowd, Chulwoo glared at me.

“You should wave too. There are no stars without fans. Don’t you know that?”

“Wave while you still can. You’ll spend the next three months staring at the ceiling of a medical clinic.”

“Let me ask you something. Why the fuck are you giving me shit?”

“You’re asking because you don’t know?”

I shrugged.

“Did you get rejected before you could even confess?”

“Who got rejected!”

Chulwoo shouted, his face flushed.

“If you hadn’t interfered, we’d already be living happily with three children!”

“…Isn’t that a little too fast?”

There were limits to how much you could speed things up. They hadn’t even known each other for half a shichen.[1027] How were they supposed to get married and have three children already?

What is he, a Command Center?[1028] He’ll hit a population of two hundred in no time.

As Cheongpung had said, even if a goose brought them by rocket delivery,[1029] it would take half a day. And since there were three children, they’d have to come as a bundle.

“It’s fine to spread your imagination’s wings, but leave me out of it. I don’t have anything to do with this Young Lady, so this is unfair.”

“Nonsense! I saw the way she looked at you!”

“The way she looked at me? What kind of look was it?”

“It was… It was… Urgh.”

Unable to continue, Chulwoo groaned and widened his eyes.

“I promise you this. You won’t be leaving here on your own two feet.”

“I’m a nice guy, so I’ll let you crawl out on all fours.”

“I’ll smash that insolent mouth of yours!”

With a roar, Chulwoo charged.

I swung my spear shaft at the punch flying toward me with a fierce aura.

Whoosh! Boom!

The violent impact sent me sliding backward. The force was unbelievable for a collision between flesh and steel.

At some point, a pair of dull-black gauntlets had appeared on his hands.

[1027] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[1028] A Command Center is a base building in the strategy game *StarCraft*, where the population limit is 200.

[1029] Rocket Delivery is the name of a rapid-delivery service offered by the South Korean retailer Coupang.

“Those Items look pretty nice. Mind if I check them out?”

“You bastard!”

Whoosh!

He truly was a mad bull.

The only difference was that he had fists instead of horns—and those fists weren’t just swinging blindly.

“Hup!”

I held my breath and swung my spear. The paths of the gauntlets and spearhead intersected, spraying sparks.

Clang-clang-clang!

I pressured him with the spear’s advantage in reach, while Chulwoo pressured me with his natural reflexes and strength.

Whoosh!

A steel-hard leg whipped toward my waist.

He was astonishingly fast and flexible for his size. I retreated and thrust my spear toward his neck.

Bang! Krrrck!

His toes cut through empty air, while his gauntlet blocked the spearhead. Chulwoo seized the blade and grinned.

“Got you.”

Krrrck!

At the same moment, an immense force yanked the spear toward him. He had probably been aiming for this from the start.

A spearman without his spear was no better than a scarecrow with its eyes open.

Of course…

I expected this much.

I released my grip and charged at Chulwoo. The triumph on his face turned to shock.

Unable to overcome the force of his own pull, both of his hands shot overhead with the spear still clutched between them.

“You…!”

“Give me back my spear.”

Crack!

“Guh!”

Something broke. Chulwoo staggered after taking my knee to the face.

Next came his solar plexus.

Thud!

“Ghn!”

Struck in a vital spot, he dropped the spear and stumbled backward. In the meantime, I calmly retrieved it.

"You bastard!"

Chulwoo finally overcame the pain and straightened up. The moment I saw him, a quiet laugh escaped me.

"Y-You're laughing?"

"Your nose is bleeding."

"You're really dead—what? A nosebleed?"

He hurriedly wiped the bridge of his nose with the back of his hand, and his face twisted in outrage.

"How dare you injure my face?"

"It's fine. You're so ugly, no one will notice."

"That makes it worse! Won't I become even uglier now?"

"…"

What the hell was with this guy? He was surprisingly self-aware.

"Gaaaaah!"

Chulwoo let out a furious roar, his eyes flashing.

"For my Senior Brother's sake, I was going to end this without going too far… But not anymore."

"Do it properly. That's why I came out here."

"Fine. I'll fight you seriously."

As if to prove his words, a faint light shimmered around Chulwoo's gauntlets.

"Fist Energy?"

It was still incomplete, but it was unmistakably Fist Energy. A vicious smile spread across his lips.

"It's too late for regrets."

Whoosh! Slice!

Sparks flew as the spearhead was cleanly severed. Chulwoo drew upon every bit of internal energy in his body, and his fists blurred.

Swish! Swish-swish-swish!

A razor-sharp gale raged around me. Each time I swung my spear against the wind raised by his fists, another handspan[1030] was sliced away.

Though incomplete, the cutting power of his materialized qi was tremendous.

Slice! Slice! Slice!

In less than a split second, the steel spear in my hands had been reduced to a sharpened metal rod the length of my forearm.

[1030] A handspan is the distance between the tips of an outstretched thumb and little finger. It varies by person but is roughly 20 cm (8 in).

“Damn. I thought I was finally getting used to it.”

At this point, it wasn’t a spear anymore. It was a short flute. A short flute.

Grumbling, I swung the steel flute through the air.

“Man, it suddenly got so light that I can’t adjust.”

Chulwoo must have found the sight amusing, because he burst into laughter.

“Ha-ha-ha! You pathetic bastard. What are you planning to do with that?”

“None of your business.”

“Are you admitting defeat already?”

“Admitting defeat, my ass. Who says I lost?”

“What gives you such confidence after losing even your weapon? If you think my Senior Brother or your brother will save you, you’re mistaken.”

I let out a quiet laugh.

“You’d better not regret this. If you ask for a draw now, I might consider it.”

“What? A draw?”

“Yeah. On the condition that you stop hitting on this Young Lady.”

“You lunatic.”

“Then negotiations are over.”

I strode toward him, casually swinging the steel flute that could no longer be called a spear.

“Come here. Let’s fight.”

A spearman was fearlessly approaching a master of fist-and-foot martial arts—and without even a proper weapon in his hands.

The crowd surrounding the Grand Training Ground began to murmur at the sight.

Chulwoo frowned as though he were looking at some bizarre creature.

“What the hell are you?”

“Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. You know that.”

“Are you acting cocky because you have some hidden move up your sleeve?”

“Who knows?”

“You aren’t planning to use some underhanded trick, are you?”

An underhanded trick.

In a way, I supposed it was something like that.

After all, it was a method permitted only to me—one no one else could see.

Open Status Window.

Only thirty paces remained between Chulwoo and me.

The System responded.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status Window
Level 71 Jin Taekyung
Class: Peak Master
Fame: 2,500 (+250)
Titles: 5 (Title effects active)
| **Returnee** (All stats +10)
| **Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi** (All stats +15, Fame +200)
| **Scion of a Prestigious Family** (All stats +5, Fame +50)
| **Gambler** (Combat-related stats +10% in one-on-one combat)
| **Intermediate Trainee** (Training speed +20%)
Strength: 255 (+55)
Stamina: 207 (+50)
Agility: 250 (+55)
Intelligence: 40 (+30)
Charm: 40 (+30)
Internal Energy: 45 years
Toughness: 200 (+50)
Remaining Points: 70
| Certain stats have been temporarily increased by the **Gambler** effect.
| Assign the remaining points.

The Gambler effect. And the seventy points I'd gained by breaking through the wall of the Peak realm.

I stepped forward without hesitation. Twenty paces away, I could see the bewilderment on Chulwoo's face.

"Lunatic."

"I hear that a lot."

Fifteen paces.

I muttered inwardly.

Assign twenty points to Strength.

Whoosh.

An invisible wind swept through me, carrying new strength into my body. My Strength, temporarily pushed past 300, churned like an active volcano.

Assign fifty points to Agility.

A second wind blew.

The very next step felt strange, as though the foot I'd just moved belonged to someone else.

Was I always this light?

It felt as though I'd stepped into an entirely new world.

I took a deep breath.

Chulwoo, not me, was the first to close the remaining ten paces.

"Damn it, I told you to surrender! Don't blame me for what happens now!"

Whoosh!

I knew this martial art. It was called Crouching Tiger Fist because it was said to subdue tigers.

Just as its ferocious opening strike was about to slam into my chest—

Whoosh.

A third wind blew.

It began at my toes and ended at my fingertips.

"Hey, Level 95."

Swish.

I jabbed the pointed steel flute into the back of Chulwoo's neck.

By then, I was already perched on his shoulder.

"Looks like I've gotten a lot stronger."

Chapter 190

Crash!

Baek Museong's body shot upward as though it had been bounced into the air.

The chair he had been sitting in moments ago clattered loudly across the ground, but he paid it no attention. Neither did anyone else present.

"What in the…"

"What happened?"

"W-What just happened?"

They had thought it was over. Jin Taekyung had displayed far greater skill than expected, but in the end, he had lost his weapon to Chulwoo's Fist Energy.

A spearman without a spear against a Peak fist fighter. The outcome was obvious.

No—it had seemed obvious.

Until a moment ago.

"How did that happen?"

"I…"

At Lee Seowol's question, Baek Museong's lips twitched. It was still difficult to believe, but for an instant, he had lost sight of Jin Taekyung's movements.

All he had seen was a pale blur.

I feel as though I've been bewitched by a ghost.

Something impossible had happened.

After remaining silent for a moment, Baek Museong opened his mouth. His voice came out tinged with embarrassment.

"I don't know."

Another wave of shock rippled through the crowd. Eunhyang, who had observed Baek Museong more closely than anyone else, widened her eyes.

"Big Brother—no, Senior Brother."

"It's true. Don't say a word."

He had entered Huashan at the age of five, become the Disciple of the Heavenly Sword True Person, and earned the reputation of being Huashan's greatest prodigy.

Though only thirty, his standing was already equal to that of the Elders, if not greater.

Huashan's greatest prodigy… Even a passing dog would laugh.

With a bitter smile, Baek Museong turned his head. A brightly smiling figure entered his view.

Ten years ago, a single meeting with Cheongpung had taught him the truth.

Baek Museong was not Huashan's greatest prodigy.

"Martial Uncle Cheongpung."

"Go ahead, Martial Nephew."

Cheongpung answered without turning his head. His eyes remained fixed on the Grand Training Ground, gleaming with interest.

"Please tell me. How did he move?"

Under everyone's expectant gaze, Cheongpung opened his mouth.

"He was fast."

Everyone promptly deflated. Fast? That was not the simple, obvious answer they had wanted.

Baek Museong spoke in an anxious voice.

"That isn't what I meant."

"I know. But that's all there is to it."

"…What do you mean?"

"My Benefactor has learned only one footwork technique and one spear technique. They're rough but practical martial arts. Neither could be called a divine art."

Cheongpung smiled brightly.

"He was simply fast. Much faster than Martial Nephew Chulwoo."

Baek Museong was left speechless.

Jin Taekyung had learned no supreme martial art and possessed no peerless internal energy. To Baek Museong, he had been nothing more than a young prodigy from a frontier martial family with exceptional martial talent.

How can such a thing be possible?

The human body had limits. Murim martial artists were special because martial arts and internal energy allowed them to surpass those limits.

Yet Cheongpung was saying that Jin Taekyung had surpassed those limits without any particularly extraordinary martial arts.

Baek Museong blurted out a vehement denial.

"Impossible."

Cheongpung shook his head.

"It's possible for my Benefactor."

"…!"

"He read the pattern of Crouching Tiger Fist and counterattacked after only two days. If Martial Nephew Chulwoo had known that, he would have tried something else."

"Crouching Tiger Fist—in two days?"

Crouching Tiger Fist was unquestionably an advanced martial art. True to its name, it was fierce enough to subdue a tiger, and its forms were exceptionally intricate.

Even Huashan Disciples whose talent had already been recognized needed a full year merely to learn its structure and forms.

Yet Jin Taekyung had done it in only two days.

My second junior brother was bound to lose.

Baek Museong's eyelids trembled faintly.

He thought he finally understood why the young Martial Uncle before him wished to remain at Jin Taekyung's side.

There was another monster.

Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

He was exactly what the name implied. Though he remained hidden in the shadows of the frontier for now, it would not be long before he spread his wings and soared into the open sky.

I was far too arrogant.

Baek Museong clenched his fists. His nails dug into his skin, but the shame hurt more than the pain.

Had he become drunk on the name of Huashan?

Before the duel had even begun, he had already decided who would win and who would lose.

I'm always telling my junior disciples to be humble, yet I failed to practice it myself.

It had been a day that gave him much to reflect upon.

Baek Museong let out a quiet sigh and offered Jin Wikyung a clasped-fist salute.

"Great Hero Jin, I apologize for my earlier rudeness."

"Ah, no."

Jin Wikyung's expression was stiff as he accepted the apology.

As far as Baek Museong knew, Jin Wikyung treasured his two younger brothers like precious jewels. Baek Museong had belittled Jin Taekyung right in front of him, so naturally he would be angry.

Baek Museong continued politely.

"My Junior Brother and I have both learned a great deal. The winner appears to have been decided, so I believe we may end the duel here."

"That would be best."

Jin Wikyung nodded gravely and rose from his seat.

A murmur too quiet for anyone to hear slipped between his lips.

"…Wow. He actually did it."

Jin Wikyung had never expected him to really win.

The Grand Training Ground was as quiet as though everyone had been drenched in cold water. The commoners and martial artists alike wore expressions as if they had seen a ghost.

Though I couldn't see his face, Chulwoo was probably wearing a similar expression. The guy who had been frozen like a statue asked in a trembling voice,

"H-How?"

"By being good."

"C-Could that have been Shifting Form and Position?"

"Your hyung's[1031] pretty fast, you know. Surprised?"

"You dodged Crouching Tiger Fist that easily…"

"You were much slower than your Martial Uncle. You'd better train hard when you get back."

It was true. Compared to Cheongpung's Crouching Tiger Fist, Chulwoo's was far slower, and his movements were much broader.

I could see the entire pattern. There was no reason I couldn't evade it—especially with an Agility stat that had broken through 300.

"Destructive power only matters if your movements are fast and precise enough to hit your opponent. Got it?"

"…How dare you lecture me?"

"How dare I? Lecture you? You still haven't figured out what's going on?"

I snorted quietly and poked the back of Chulwoo's neck with the steel flute.

Its sharp edge dug into his skin, and his massive body shuddered. Oh, this was fun.

"Rest easy! Huashan's Serial Confession Man has been dealt with by the Taiyuan Jin Family's Steel Flute Murderer!"

"You bastard!"

"Ah-ah, don't move. I'd rather not draw blood."

"You're dead the moment you come down."

"Maybe. But the duel seems to be over, so try again next time."

Just then, I spotted Jin Wikyung rising from his seat.

Chulwoo would never surrender of his own accord, so it seemed Jin Wikyung intended to end the duel here.

His voice, reinforced with internal energy, rang throughout the Grand Training Ground.

"You both fought well!"

"Waaaaah!"

The crowd finally came to its senses and answered with a deafening cheer.

[1031] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance. Taekyung uses it to refer to himself when addressing Chulwoo.

They had witnessed a duel between Peak masters with their own eyes—something difficult to see even if you were willing to pay for it. Their reaction was understandable.

"All right, that's enough. Good work."

The Quest had been much easier than expected.

The moment I pulled the steel flute away from Chulwoo's neck with a cheerful smile—

Grab!

A hand as large as a pot lid clamped around my wrist.

"Huh?"

"It isn't over yet!"

For a moment, I had forgotten what kind of man Chulwoo was.

A man blinded by love. A man who had spent twenty-five years dead inside until his heart finally began to beat. A man who could neither live nor die without Lee Seowol's permission…

In short, a madman. "Fucking bastard" was a close synonym.

There's no way a guy like that would give up so easily.

Whatever else could be said about him, he had been born with one extraordinary gift: divine strength. Even Cheongpung had to concede that much to him.

Chulwoo spoke with absolute confidence.

"Once I get my hands on someone, it's over."

Sure, I'd let my guard down, but weren't this bastard's manners absolute shit?

Ah, a man blinded by love.

I let out a heavy sigh.

"Chul-thetic, Pawoo."[1032]

"Are those your last words?"

"No. Words of wisdom."

"You spout nonsense whenever you get the chance. Give up on Young Lady Lee, and I'll let you off here."

"Did I ever tell you?"

"What?"

"Young Lady Lee proposed to me."

"You goddamn soooooon of a—!"

A scream erupted from the crowd.

Veins bulged across Chulwoo's entire body as he tried to slam me into the ground with tremendous force.

Tried to.

[1032] Taekyung mangles "Pathetic, Chulwoo" by swapping the opening sounds.

“What are you doing?”

“Hnnnnngh!”

His flushed face turned pale, then purple.

An immense force dragged at my wrist, but I didn’t budge an inch.

“Oh, you’re pretty strong.”

Between the temporary boost from the **Gambler** Title and the points I had just allocated, the strength now coursing through my body far surpassed human limits.

Not even Chulwoo, with his enormous frame and innate divine strength, could overpower me.

“At this level, your Strength stat must be well over 200.”

“W-What is this?”

“Bastard.”

My grinning face was reflected in his horrified eyes.

“Your hyung’s[1033] Strength alone is over 300. I was stronger than you even before I allocated those points.”

Fist Energy? It meant nothing if it couldn’t hit me. Strength, speed—I surpassed him in every respect. Even if we had kept fighting as we were, I would have won in the end.

Even so, there was a simple reason I had bothered allocating the points.

“Guys like you need a proper beating, or you’ll just start acting up again.”

“You son of a—!”

Thwack!

My fist shot out like lightning and struck him squarely in the temple. The muscular giant staggered, then collapsed limply.

Boom!

At the same moment, the sound I had been waiting for rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

The Quest There Is a Man Who Loved You So Much has been successfully completed!

You received a large amount of EXP as a Reward!

You received a large amount of Fame as a Reward!

Level Up!

Level Up!

“Buuurp. Thanks for the meal.”

[1033] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance. Taekyung uses it to refer to himself when addressing Chulwoo.

After a brief silence, thunderous cheers engulfed the Grand Training Ground.

At the main gate of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, some six hundred meters[1034] from the Grand Training Ground, a low-ranking martial artist who had been listening with perked ears to the resounding cheers made a fuss.

“Did you hear that?”

Someone leaning crookedly against the gate answered.

“I did.”

“They say the Third Young Master defeated the Defeated Flower Fist!”

“Yeah.”

“…Why are you reacting like that? We’re talking about the Defeated Flower Fist, one of Huashan’s Three Plum Blossom Elites!”

“I know, you idiot.”

“The Third Young Master defeated the Defeated Flower Fist! Captain, aren’t you surprised?”

“No. It doesn’t surprise me anymore.”

Hyuk Mujin, Captain of the Gatekeepers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, yawned widely and continued.

“I’ve followed that fellow around and seen all kinds of things. Defeating the Defeated Flower Fist is the least he’d have to do before I could call him my lord.”

“Gasp! You’ve already thrown your lot in with him?”

“What do you mean, thrown my lot in?”

Hyuk Mujin snorted.

“One day, my lord said to me, ‘Listen, Martial Artist Hyuk. Become my right hand. Without you…‘”

The low-ranking martial artist cut in with a dubious look.

“Wait a second. Are we talking about the Third Young Master? That doesn’t sound like him at all.”

“Did you just interrupt me?”

“Captain, that’s not what I meant.”

“Why, you little—are you close to him? Do you know him better than I do?”

“No.”

“Listen here, kid. I’ve crossed the boundary between life and death with him! I’ve eaten with him! We’ve done everything together!”

“…Yes. Please continue.”

“You should’ve said that from the start. Anyway, back then, my lord…”

[1034] Six hundred meters is about 0.37 mi.

Hyuk Mujin had just calmed down and was about to continue when a voice interrupted him.

“This is excessively noisy for a gathering.”

“What would the likes of them know? It seems they were in such high spirits that they let every Tom, Dick, and Harry inside.”

“Tsk, tsk.”

The voices drifted from beyond the faint darkness that had settled over the area.

Hyuk Mujin clicked his tongue and asked the low-ranking martial artist,

“Weren’t all the distinguished guests on the list already here?”

“Well, everyone who said they would visit today has arrived, at least.”

“Then who’s this? Someone who heard the rumors and came over?”

“Wouldn’t that be likely?”

“First, double-check the list and stay here.”

“Yes, sir.”

Grumbling inwardly, Hyuk Mujin straightened from where he had been leaning against the gate.

Then he shouted toward the four silhouettes drawing closer.

“Halt! I am Hyuk Mujin, Captain of the Gatekeepers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. State your identity and purpose!”

An elderly voice answered.

“Roaring Fury Swordsman.”

“Roaring Fury Swordsman, is it? What sect?”

“Zhongnan Sect.”

“Zhongnan Sect, then. I need to check the others’ faces as well, so come closer… Oh.”

Hyuk Mujin froze midway through scrawling *Zhongnan Sect* on the wooden tablet.

He slowly raised his head and saw a gaunt old man accompanied by three middle-aged martial artists with arrogant expressions.

“Z-Zhongnan Sect?”

The old man at the front stared at Hyuk Mujin with blazing eyes.

“Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung. Take me to those two bastards at once.”

Chapter 191

As the unconscious Chulwoo was carried away, Jin Wikyung stepped forward.

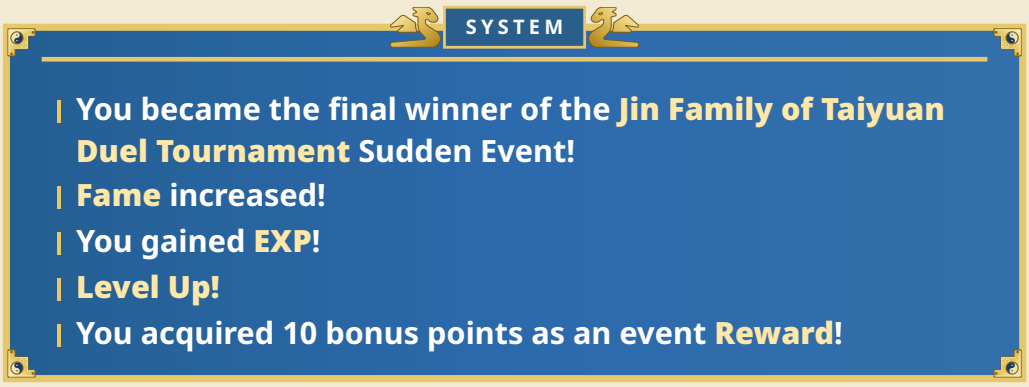
“Does anyone else wish to challenge him?”

I had literally wiped the floor with Chulwoo, who had been so overwhelmingly strong. There was no chance anyone else would step up.

When no one came forward, Jin Wikyung shouted with an expression of pure delight,

“Then the final winner of this duel tournament is the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung!”

Ding.



With that unexpected alert, the Grand Training Ground erupted into absolute madness.

“Waaaaah!”

“Long live the Jin Family of Taiyuan! Long live the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi defeated the Defeated Flower Fist!”

“Kiyah-hoo!”

Who was that? Now there was a man who knew how to party.

In any case, the atmosphere in the Grand Training Ground grew hotter than anything a rock festival could offer.

A child hurled his candied fruit into the air, while a white-haired old man let out a wild cry and snapped his cane over his knee.

“Waaaaah!”

“Hiyah!”

The martial artists were even worse.

Shanxi Murim had long been treated as a backwater. I had merely defeated one Serial Confession Man, but to them, it was as good as winning a battle of pride against Shaanxi Murim.

“Lady of the House! Bring me a bottle of strong liquor!”

"That dumpling I ate twenty years ago finally went down! Order whatever you want! Everything's on me today!"

Don't call the Lady of the House. And don't order everything.

It was all coming out of the Jin Family of Taiyuan's pockets anyway, but the people drunk on Shanxi pride had completely lost their minds.

They're going wild.

Since a large portion of them were martial artists, carrying weapons was standard. I was worried that someone might get drunk on the excitement and cause trouble.

Sure enough, some lunatic suddenly shouted,

"Everyone, draw your swords!"

Clang-clang-clang!

Hundreds of weapons were drawn in a flash of reflected light.

"Wave them in order, starting from the front!"

"Waaaaah!"

Clang-clang-clang! Clang-clang-clang!

Wait, were they doing the wave here?

As I watched this cutting-edge new cheering culture unfold, I muttered in disbelief,

"This is a complete…"

"Shitshow."

I had started the sentence, but I hadn't said the second half.

An elderly voice pierced my ears with perfect clarity. I looked around, but all I could see were excited people.

Who was that?

Even amid the cacophony, the voice had sounded as though its owner were standing right beside me. Whoever he was, he was a master—and one with profound internal energy at that.

Just as several of us turned to search for the speaker—

"Ha!"

Gooooong.

Was this what the lion's roar I had read about in martial arts novels sounded like?

The ground rumbled and the air trembled. The more fainthearted commoners passed out or collapsed screaming.

"Eeeeeek!"

"Gah!"

The festive Grand Training Ground descended into chaos in an instant.

The commoners trembled, and the martial artists stood frozen. Through the crowd, scattered as though a bomb had gone off, an old man strolled leisurely into view.

"Much better."

He was tall and gaunt. His sharp gaze swept across the gathering before meeting mine.

I was standing in the middle of the duel platform, and a young man who remained perfectly fine while staring back at him was bound to stand out.

The old man looked me up and down, then spoke.

"Is it you?"

"Excuse me?"

"Cheongpung or Jin Taekyung. Which one are you?"

What the hell was going on?

Countless thoughts flashed through my mind. I made my decision in that brief instant.

"Neither."

"You're not?"

"No. You must have mistaken me for someone else."

Whatever was going on, I might as well deny everything and see what happened.

One glance told me enough. I didn't know who he was or where he had come from, but he certainly didn't seem to have any warm feelings toward me.

"Is that so?"

"I've never heard either name in my life."

The old man beckoned behind him.

"Come here."

"Yes, Elder."

Four people who had been obscured by the crowd emerged. As it happened, I had met every one of them before.

One face in particular was impossible to mistake.

Hyuk Mujin?

Wasn't he supposed to be standing guard? What was he doing over there?

Pale as a sheet, Hyuk Mujin came forward as though the three middle-aged men beside him were dragging him along. Their faces were familiar too.

What were their epithets again?

Oh, right. The Three Hands of Zhongnan.

Just as I finally remembered the extras' collective epithet, the unidentified old man spoke to the four of them.

"Find them."

Hyuk Mujin and Gong Ilhyuk, the middle-aged man with a splint on his arm, pointed at me simultaneously.

“Captain! Please save me!”

“That’s him! He’s Jin Taekyung!”

“…”

“…”

Well, I was caught.

After a brief silence, the old man asked me,

“Are you really Jin Taekyung?”

I bowed as politely as I could.

“Nice to meet you. My name is Jin Taekyung.”

“…What kind of lunatic is this?”

As the old man stared at me in disbelief, three people landed lightly with a rush of wind.

Jin Wikyung, Baek Museong, and Cheongpung.

“I am Jin Wikyung, Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. May I ask this Senior’s name?”

“Ahem. You’re the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

The question had been directed at the old man, but Gong Ilhyuk was the one who stepped forward.

Jin Wikyung frowned at the interruption.

“That is correct. And who might you be?”

“I am Gong Ilhyuk, one of the Three Hands of Zhongnan. I am a second-generation Disciple of the Great Zhongnan Sect, and Great Hero Gong Iljung, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord and Sect Leader, is my father’s cousin.”

He was still going on about his father’s cousin.

It made me want to slap him across the mouth with the hind leg of a boiled chicken.

Upon learning Gong Ilhyuk’s identity, Jin Wikyung muttered almost as if groaning.

“The Zhongnan Sect?”

Gong Ilhyuk was a well-connected hack who threw his weight around, but the name of the Zhongnan Sect was another matter.

The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were the towering powers that moved the present-day Murim.

Emboldened by the momentum, Gong Ilhyuk continued smugly,

“And this gentleman is Great Hero Song Il, an Elder of our sect.”

That old man is an Elder of the Zhongnan Sect?

I had expected him to be a master, but it seemed his status was even more impressive than I had imagined. Jin Wikyung and Baek Museong's expressions hardened.

"The Roaring Fury Swordsman…!"

"This junior of Murim, Baek Museong, pays his respects to Senior Song."

The old man—the Roaring Fury Swordsman—silently looked down at the two of them as they hurriedly paid their respects.

His voice carried the composure and arrogance of a powerful man.

"Baek Museong? Are you Huashan's Lone Crane?"

"Yes. It is an epithet far too generous for me."

"So it seems. You're inferior to your Master in his youth."

What an insufferable old bastard.

Still, I had to admit his clout was extraordinary.

Not only had the Roaring Fury Swordsman casually belittled Baek Museong, who was practically an object of admiration, in front of everyone, but he had also spoken of Huashan's Sect Leader, the Heavenly Sword True Person, as though he were some old neighborhood friend.

His seniority in Murim seemed every bit as formidable as his martial arts.

"I will continue striving."

"Hm. You certainly know how to make yourself sound good. But if the Heavenly Sword True Person sent you…"

As he watched Baek Museong bow his head without another word, the Roaring Fury Swordsman's eyes flashed.

His gaze had shifted to Cheongpung, who stood there looking blank.

"So it's you. The Sword Saint's heir."

Cheongpung asked with a puzzled expression,

"You know my grandfather?"

"Of course. How could I possibly not know him?"

Judging by the old man's expression, theirs probably hadn't been a pleasant relationship.

As the situation grew more serious, Jin Wikyung asked with a stiff face,

"May I ask what brings you here?"

"I came to collect a debt."

"A debt?"

"Yes. A debt owed for daring to mock the Great Zhongnan Sect and injure one of our Disciples."

His blade-sharp gaze shot toward Cheongpung and me.

Gong Ilhyuk stepped forward, waving his splinted arm.

“Do you see this? I suffered this injury at Prince Shangshan’s residence, where I had gone by invitation. A physician examined it and said I would need at least six months to recover.”

Cheongpung spoke with an apologetic expression.

“I hit you gently… Did it hurt that much?”

Cruel bastard. He was killing Gong Ilhyuk twice over.

Gong Ilhyuk’s face flushed red at the public humiliation.

“You bastard! You ambushed me, yet you still have the nerve to say that!”

I muttered in disbelief,

“Ambushed, my ass. You grabbed him by the collar first and got your ass handed to you.”

“Shut your mouth! When I think of how you two mocked our sect and what you did to me, I wouldn’t be satisfied even if I chewed you up and swallowed you!”

That was how a fight between children turned into a fight between adults.

Jin Wikyung and Baek Museong’s faces twisted sharply.

“Chew him up and swallow him? Did you just say that to our youngest?”

“How dare you call him a bastard! Great Hero Gong, watch your words! Though our sects may differ, there is still such a thing as seniority in Murim. How could you…”

“Heh heh heh.”

At the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s grating laughter, Jin Wikyung and Baek Museong fell silent.

“Seniority, you say. You chose your words well.”

“…”

“…”

“This old man is the Senior Brother of our sect’s Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord. I am of the same seniority as the Heavenly Sword True Person of Huashan, so there should be no problem.”

Bringing up seniority had been a mistake.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman’s martial arts were formidable enough, and now he was crushing them beneath the sheer weight of his seniority. Neither Jin Wikyung nor Baek Museong could contend with him. Not even Cheongpung, the Sword Saint’s Disciple, could.

“Am I wrong?”

When no one answered, the Roaring Fury Swordsman turned to Cheongpung.

“You injured a Disciple of the Zhongnan Sect. Are you prepared to face the consequences?”

This was why words were so frightening.

There was no explanation of how it had happened. Only the result remained.

Baek Museong hurriedly interjected.

“Senior, we must first establish the rights and wrongs of this matter.”

Cheongpung shrank in on himself and muttered,

“I only gave him a gentle tap.”

“Are you saying you didn’t do it?”

“That’s not what I mean. I did hit him, but I didn’t know he would be hurt that badly.”

Gong Ilhyuk seized the opening and lunged in.

“It was an obvious attempt to kill!”

“Did you hear that?”

“It really wasn’t.”

As Cheongpung fumbled for words, the Roaring Fury Swordsman continued in a cutting voice.

“I will formally lodge a complaint with Huashan over this matter, so don’t you dare think you can wriggle out of it.”

“Elder, the government and Murim do not interfere in each other’s affairs. Furthermore, the officials present at the time were favorably disposed toward them. I fear they may give false testimony.”

“You are right. I will take measures.”

It was all rigged from the start.

Baek Museong bit down hard on his lip at the unfair treatment, and the next target of their arrows was obvious.

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan will seal its gates until our sect sends someone.”

“…What did you just say?”

Jin Wikyung said what I wanted to say for me. No—everyone nearby who had heard the Roaring Fury Swordsman must have been thinking the same thing.

Seal our gates?

What kind of bullshit was that?

It was true that I had humiliated Gong Ilhyuk a little.

But that had been directed solely at Gong Ilhyuk. I could swear that I had never said anything to mock or insult the Zhongnan Sect.

And they wanted the Jin Family to seal its gates over that?

Even with the condition that it would last only until the Zhongnan Sect sent someone, the order itself was already a humiliation.

“That is unjust!”

At Jin Wikyung’s shout, the Roaring Fury Swordsman raised his eyes.

“What did you say?”

“How can you order us to seal our gates before even investigating what happened and determining who was at fault? Is this the way of the Nine Sects and One Gang —or rather, the way of the Zhongnan Sect?”

“How dare you!”

“Our family will not accept this!”

“If you refuse to accept it?”

Ssssss.

A tremendous aura rose from the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s entire body like wildfire.

It felt as though a sword were pointed directly between my brows. My skin prickled.

“If you refuse, what will you do?”

“…!”

“This is Murim. Have you forgotten?”

A surge of irritation suddenly welled up inside me.

I already knew how the world worked. I had experienced it more times than I cared to remember.

People ignored you because you had no money, looked down on you because you lacked powerful backing, and scorned you because your talent was insignificant.

It’s the same here.

Murim and the modern world were different, yet so much alike.

Those with power turned lies into truth and truth into lies.

They pressured the weak and crushed them underfoot. To people like that, it was all natural. All inevitable.

Just like the Roaring Fury Swordsman standing before me.

Drip. Drip.

Blood trickled from the fist I had clenched without realizing it.

I stared down at the drops landing one by one on the ground and exhaled a hot breath.

“Ah, fuck. This is fucking bullshit.”

No one had dared to speak, so everyone heard the profanity that burst from my mouth.

It felt as though something invisible had shattered with a sharp crack.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman asked with an expression of disbelief,

“…What did you just say?”

Swearing had been a mistake. Since I was the reason this had happened, I should have swallowed it no matter what.

That was the best way to resolve the situation smoothly.

But…

“It’s fucking bullshit. I said it’s fucking bullshit. You fucking assholes. There’s a limit to how much you can throw your weight around.”

I couldn’t take it anymore.

They could call me thoughtless or a young fool who knew nothing about the world.

I had no desire to replay all the things I had been sick of experiencing in reality here in Murim.

I apologized to Jin Wikyung.

“I’m sorry. I know I’m supposed to put up with it even when it’s fucking bullshit, but they were being so fucking shitty about it that it felt twice as fucking shitty, and I couldn’t let it slide.”

Jin Wikyung, who looked half dazed, went through an astonishing range of expressions.

His face twisted, then relaxed. After showing several different expressions in a short span of time, he finally let out a quiet laugh.

“Honestly, I thought it was fucking bullshit too.”

Those words pulled the trigger.

Flames hotter than lava poured from the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s eyes.

“You bastards… must be desperate to die.”

Shing.

As he spat the words through clenched teeth, he drew his sword. Layer upon layer of Sword Energy enveloped the snow-white blade.

It burned more fiercely than any Sword Energy I had ever seen.

The instant it pointed at me—

“If you kill that guy, you die too.”

At the clear, ringing voice that came from somewhere, the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s body abruptly froze.

Chapter 192

“Ah, fuck. This is fucking bullshit, seriously.”

…What?

Song Il thought he was dreaming.

Who was he? He was Song Il, the Roaring Fury Swordsman. Even now that his junior brother, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, had become Sect Leader, he still treated Song Il with the utmost courtesy and respect.

And yet—what the fuck? Fucking bullshit?

Did I hear that wrong?

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. The youngest son of the tiny Jin Family of Taiyuan.

A brat who had only just turned twenty with the new year.

He couldn’t believe that such a brat had said those words to him—a Great Zhongnan Sect Elder and one of the heroes of the Great Faction War.

No. He couldn’t accept it.

“What did you just say?”

Any hope that he had misheard was crushed the next moment by Jin Taekyung’s reply.

“It’s fucking bullshit. I said it’s fucking bullshit! You fucking assholes! There’s a limit to how much you can throw your weight around.”

“…”

After cursing up a storm, Jin Taekyung turned to Jin Wikyung.

“I’m sorry. I know I’m supposed to put up with it even when it’s fucking bullshit, but they were being so fucking shitty about it that it felt twice as fucking shitty, and I couldn’t let it slide.”

“Honestly, I thought it was fucking bullshit too.”

Those words from Jin Wikyung were the finishing touch.

The disbelief in Song Il’s eyes slowly gave way to light. A blazing light.

It was an immense fury he hadn’t felt in a very long time.

“You bastards…”

Hot breath escaped between Song Il’s teeth as he lost all reason.

“You must be desperate to die.”

Shing.

His treasured sword, which had cut down countless enemies, emerged from its scabbard. It didn’t matter whether the Jin Family of Taiyuan belonged to the orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction, or even practiced demonic, heterodox arts.

If Song Il had thought about the consequences before causing trouble, he never would have earned the title Roaring Fury Swordsman.

I'll kill every last one of you.

Song Il truly intended to kill them. As though to prove it, powerful Sword Energy surged like waves.

He had trained in the Zhongnan Sect's ultimate technique, the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords, all his life.

Although he had not achieved Great Completion, it was more than enough to carve these insolent fools into chunks of meat with a single sword strike.

I'll kill you first.

He had already decided who would die first.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. He would chew up that young brat's tongue and swallow it.

Just as Song Il was about to unleash his Sword Energy, his eyes bloodshot—

"If you kill that guy, you die too."

At the voice that came from somewhere, Song Il's body abruptly froze.

Not because of what the words meant. Because he couldn't determine where they had come from.

I can't tell? Me?

That was impossible.

But the voice that followed made it clear that this was real.

"A man your age, picking on a child like this. Tsk, tsk."

Front, back, above, below, left, right.

Song Il couldn't distinguish where the voice was coming from. Its owner was nowhere and everywhere at once.

Th-this is…

At last, Song Il realized the identity of the voice, and his body trembled.

Six-Harmonies Voice Transmission!

If Sound Transmission, the art of conveying sound through internal energy, was the exclusive province of Peak masters, Six-Harmonies Voice Transmission was a martial art permitted only to those who had reached the realm beyond it.

Supreme Peak. A great realm that only a tiny fraction of the chosen few could enter.

How could someone like that…

Why? Why was such a person interfering with him?

Song Il shouted as if having a fit.

"Who are you! I am Elder Song Il of the Great Zhongnan Sect, the Roaring Fury Swordsman! Show yourself at once!"

"'This old man'? 'Elder'? Hahahahahaha!"

Thunderous laughter rang out from every direction, backed by internal energy so vast that no one dared guess at its limits.

The commoners who had never learned martial arts fell flat on their faces, crying out to the Jade Emperor,[1035] while the martial artists trembled in awe.

“Can you not hear me!”

“Ha, hahaha! Ah, I’m laughing so hard my stomach’s going to split.”

“You insolent bastard!”

Having lost his composure to anger and fear, Song Il caught sight of Jin Taekyung.

Unlike the people staring around in shock, Jin Taekyung alone was gazing into the empty air. There was even an enigmatic smile on his lips.

Almost as though he were mocking Song Il.

That bastard!

Ssssss!

The Sword Energy that had faltered for a moment surged again. Pointing his sword at Jin Taekyung, Song Il looked around and shouted,

“Show yourself at once! Or I’ll kill this bastard!”

The laughter that had shaken heaven and earth abruptly stopped.

“What? Kill that guy?”

“I’ll count to three.”

A triumphant smile spread across Song Il’s lips.

He didn’t know where the voice’s owner was, but the troublemaker’s weakness was Jin Taekyung. The fluster in the other man’s voice was proof.

“One!”

“Heh, look at you. You’ve grown even more vicious since I last saw you.”

Since they last met?

Song Il’s mind raced. Judging by those words, they had clearly met before, but…

Wait. Could that voice be…

Song Il flinched as someone came to mind, but quickly gritted his teeth.

That was impossible. There was no way that old monster was still alive.

As though trying to shake off his fear, he shouted even louder.

“Two!”

“Phew. Fine, I understand. I’ll come out now, so wait right there! But if you touch even a single hair on him, I’ll make you pay!”

Song Il’s strength left him all at once.

His gamble had worked. The unidentified Supreme Peak master wanted Jin Taekyung alive. And he was farther away than Song Il had expected.

[1035] The Jade Emperor is the heavenly ruler in Daoist tradition.

"Fifty jang.[1036] Stay at least fifty jang away. If you come any closer, this bastard is as good as dead—"

At that exact moment—

"Three."

Song Il doubted his own eyes and ears.

Barely three jang[1037] away, Jin Taekyung calmly spoke again.

"I said three. You fucking old bastard. Are you deaf?"

"You bastard. Are you desperate to die?"

"Try killing me. If you can."

"…What?"

"You know what? If you can't kill me with one sword strike, you're next."

"…!"

"Let's see who dies."

Jin Taekyung smiled brightly and spread both arms.

"He's coming."

He was coming. Those two words sent a chill down Song Il's spine.

Song Il unconsciously took a step back.

Then—

Whoosh.

A faint rush of wind pierced his ears. A presence was rapidly closing in from behind at an unbelievable speed.

This is…

Every hair on Song Il's body stood on end. The instincts he had honed by crossing the threshold of death countless times whispered to him.

It's already too late. Fall back. Now.

But—

I am Song Il, the Roaring Fury Swordsman!

Sssshhhhh!

The Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords, which he had brought to nine-tenths mastery, erupted. His Sword Energy split into twenty-four streams and shot forward.

In the slowed world, Jin Taekyung's figure was reflected in Song Il's wide-open eyes.

Swish, swish, swish, swish, swish!

[1036] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 151.5 m (497 ft); three *jang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

[1037] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 151.5 m (497 ft); three *jang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

He narrowly evaded the twenty-four streams of Sword Energy as they closed in from every direction.

The only price he paid for evading the Roaring Fury Swordsman's strike was torn clothing and scattered drops of blood.

"This is impossible—!"

Song Il, still in shock, was given no chance to attack again.

Something firm and hot clamped around his wrist just as he tried to unleash the second form.

Clench!

"You fucking bastard… Didn't I tell you not to touch a single hair on him?"

A low voice. Two eyes blazing so fiercely that their red seemed to burn blue.

Only then did Song Il realize that he could no longer hear the wind.

And that he had touched someone he never should have touched.

"Y-you… How could you…"

"The Zhongnan brat has grown a lot. You can't even recognize an adult anymore."

The old monster who had inflicted an unforgettable humiliation upon him long ago had stepped out of his memories and now stood before him.

Song Il let out a shrill scream.

"Fire King—!"

A terrifying smile appeared on Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled lips.

"Yes. It's me."

On New Year's Day, the Fire King descended upon the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

The weight of that name pressed down upon the entire training ground.

One God, Three Saints, Ten Kings.

They were gods, stars, and kings who towered above the countless martial artists of Murim. Absolute beings who stood closest to the title of greatest under heaven.

Jeok Cheongang wore shabby clothes and had a slight frame, but his presence was that of a giant.

And the giant's eyes turned toward me.

"You crazy bastard. Are you desperate to die?"

I never thought that voice could sound so welcome. I sank to the ground on the spot.

"Whew. I almost died for real."

"You would have if this old man hadn't stepped in."

"Yes, thank you. I won't forget this kindness."

At my soulless reply, Jeok Cheongang glared at me.

“You lost your fear in half a day. Do you want to die?”

Only half a day?

Come to think of it, I had parted with Jeok Cheongang that very morning.

The first day of the new year had been so eventful that it felt as though a month had passed.

I answered in an exhausted voice.

“If you’re going to kill me, please put it off as long as possible.”

“That is the plan.”

Jeok Cheongang turned his head and added,

“First, I’ll deal with this insolent bastard.”

Insolent bastard?

How many people in the world could call the Senior Brother of the Zhongnan Sect’s Sect Leader—and an Elder at that—something like that?

“Ah, ah…”

Song Il, the Roaring Fury Swordsman, was trembling from head to toe.

Judging by the way Jeok Cheongang kept calling him a brat, they must have known each other in the past. Apparently, it hadn’t been a particularly warm relationship.

“It’s been a long time. So, did those broken bones heal properly?”

“H-how could you…”

“‘You’? Was that directed at me?”

The Fire King blinked as though he were looking at some fascinating creature, then let out a hollow laugh.

“You’ve grown a lot.”

Smack.

It was a sight money couldn’t buy.

Jeok Cheongang slapped the Roaring Fury Swordsman across the face with his wrinkled hand. His hand moved so slowly it seemed to take forever, yet the Roaring Fury Swordsman didn’t dare evade it even though he could see it coming.

“I remember when I first saw you. You were barely twenty, a young pup.”

Smack.

“You were arrogant and rude, causing all kinds of trouble while hiding behind your sect’s prestige. And now you’re an Elder of the Zhongnan Sect?”

Smack.

“Once, I saved you when you were about to die, and what you said afterward was truly something. Was it, ‘Why are you stealing someone else’s battle credit?‘”

Smack.

“If it hadn’t been for your Master’s request, I would have broken your neck instead of your leg.”

Smack, smack, smack!

The ordinary slaps carried not a trace of internal energy, yet the half-gray-haired Roaring Fury Swordsman shrank like a beaten child.

The ease and arrogance of a powerful man had vanished from his eyes, replaced by humiliation, fury, and fear.

Jeok Cheongang spat out the words with the expression of a man looking at a bug.

“You fucking moron. Did all those years go straight up your ass?”

What should I do?

I was starting to like the old man more and more.

Jin Wikyung and Hyuk Mujin were already gazing at Jeok Cheongang with love in their eyes.

“You call yourself an Elder of the Nine Sects and One Gang,[1038] yet you threaten commoners and use your power to arbitrarily order a sect to seal its gates? If your Master saw this, he would be wailing in the afterlife.”

“…”

“Who is the Sect Leader now?”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman answered in a stammering voice.

“M-my junior brother. The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord…”

“Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord? I’ve never heard that title in my life. Is that why a piece of trash like you struts around calling himself an Elder of the Zhongnan Sect?”

What audacity—to treat the Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect like some nobody.

As if having his sect insulted weren’t enough, the Roaring Fury Swordsman had suddenly been reduced to a piece of trash. His face twisted violently.

When he silently lowered his head to hide his humiliation and anger, Jeok Cheongang’s tiger-like eyes widened.

“Is your mouth just for decoration? Why aren’t you saying anything?”

“…Great Hero Jeok. I-I merely…”

“Shut your mouth!”

I made up my mind.

I was going to create a fan club.

At this very moment, the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was practically the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s idol.

Is this what it feels like to bathe in a hot spring filled with soda?

Even my white blood cells seemed to fizz with carbonation.

[1038] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a major grouping of martial-arts factions in Murim fiction.

It felt like chugging a can of beer so cold it had begun to ice over after finishing a raid on a sweltering summer day.

Wave after wave of exhilarating refreshment swept through my entire body.

Fire. King. Is. The. Best.

Of course, that was from the perspective of someone watching.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman had been publicly humiliated in front of countless commoners and martial artists alike. His body shook. Perhaps that was why the humiliation and anger he felt in that instant overcame his fear of the Fire King.

“T-this is a matter between our sect and the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“What?”

“I’m saying that this is not a matter for Great Hero Jeok to involve himself in.”

“This old man has no business involving himself?”

Jeok Cheongang studied the Roaring Fury Swordsman, who had forced out those words in a trembling voice.

His tightly clenched fist twitched as if he were deciding where to hit him so everyone would agree he had chosen the perfect spot.

Hit him! Please, just hit him once!

As though he had heard my encouragement, Jeok Cheongang raised his hand high.

Then, the next moment, his wrinkled finger pointed at me.

“Do you see that bastard?”

“…?”

What the hell? Why was I suddenly involved?

Just as confusion spread across every face, mine included, the Fire King continued.

“I entrusted the Fire Gate Clan’s sacred treasure to that boy.”

“…!”

“…!”

Silence descended upon the Grand Training Ground.

Wordless shock spread endlessly through the crowd.

Chapter 193

The Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure.

The moment that unfamiliar phrase sprang from the Fire King's mouth, the Roaring Fury Swordsman's eyes bulged as though they were about to tear apart.

"W-what do you mean?"

"You're not even seventy, and your ears are already clogged? I'll say it one more time, so listen carefully."

Jeok Cheongang jerked his chin toward me, looking irritated.

"This old man entrusted our sect's sacred treasure to that brat. Got it?"

"…"

"…"

What do you mean, got it?

I looked around in bewilderment. Everyone, including Jin Wikyung and Baek Museong, was staring back and forth between Jeok Cheongang and me in shock.

Amid all this chaos, the only person unaffected spoke up.

"Benefactor, what's the Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure? Show me too."

I couldn't answer Cheongpung's question.

I don't know either, you little shit.

The Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure? What was he talking about?

I swore I had never heard or seen such an item.

The only things I had received from Jeok Cheongang were the martial arts manual for the Flame Divine Palm and a sword…

Wait.

"Could it be?"

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue at my questioning look.

"You've been carrying it on your back this whole time and still didn't know? What a moron."

I felt as if someone had struck me in the back of the head with a hammer.

I hurriedly untied the knot holding it firmly in place. When I unwound the layers of cloth, an old, crude scabbard appeared.

The Unnamed Sword.

The very thing Jopil had stolen from his Master, only for me to take it from him.

I gripped the hilt and drew.

Shing!

With a sound that made every hair on my body stand on end, the pure-white blade slid free.

It shone in the surrounding darkness like some holy sword from legend, drawing gasps from the crowd.

So this really is… the Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure?

Until now, I had never once questioned it.

Why Jopil had stolen it from Jeok Cheongang. Why, unlike the Flame Divine Palm or the Blazing Flame Divine Pill, it bore the strange description *Unnamed Sword*.

I was staring blankly at the blade when—

"T-this is impossible!"

It was the Roaring Fury Swordsman. Unlike him, overwhelmed by extreme confusion and excitement, Jeok Cheongang's expression was perfectly calm.

"What is?"

"T-that…"

"This old man entrusted the Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure to that brat. Even with a head full of nothing but shit, surely you understand what that means."

That snapped me back to my senses.

I had been so absorbed in the sword that I had momentarily forgotten what it meant for a sect's sacred treasure to be entrusted to someone—especially the treasure of the Fire Gate Clan, whose lineage had been passed from one person to the next for hundreds of years.

At the same time, Cheongpung's words from barely half a day ago flashed through my mind.

Aren't you trying to take Benefactor as your Disciple?

At the time, I had dismissed it as ridiculous nonsense and laughed it off.

But now…

Fuck. I don't know either.

As I swallowed dryly, the Roaring Fury Swordsman pointed a finger at me.

Before he could speak, however, Jeok Cheongang's terrifying gaze locked him in place.

"This old man said he entrusted our sect's sacred treasure to him."

That was all.

But his opponent was none other than the Fire King.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman had no courage left to argue. He chewed on his lip, then suddenly glared at me.

"You bastard. You're lucky."

Why is this old man starting shit with me again?

Jeok Cheongang said nothing. Did he expect me to handle this much on my own?

I shrugged at the Roaring Fury Swordsman.

"You've got the wrong man. I'm actually really unlucky."

If I were fucking lucky, would I have met a piece of shit like you?

The situation had been a hair's breadth from exploding when Jeok Cheongang appeared, so I wasn't sure whether to call it great misfortune or great fortune.

"Anyway, it was nice meeting you. Have a safe trip home."

"You cunning bastard. Why don't you try what you did earlier?"

"What I did earlier? Oh, you mean when I said it was fucking bullshit?"

Before the Roaring Fury Swordsman could respond, I bowed my head.

"I apologize for that. I've never been able to tolerate injustice. Please forgive a slip of the tongue from a junior far beneath you. Great. Hero."

"…!"

The Roaring Fury Swordsman trembled. Blood dripped from his tightly clenched fists.

Looking at him, I saw myself from only a few minutes earlier. The difference between us was that I had refused to submit to the Roaring Fury Swordsman, while he had submitted to the Fire King.

Those who rely on power kneel before greater power. Realizing that fundamental truth of the world again was satisfying, but not entirely.

If anything, it left me bitter.

This leaves a bad taste in my mouth.

If Jeok Cheongang hadn't been here, the humiliation and fury that man now felt would have belonged to me and the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

If a few of the people here joined forces, defeating the Roaring Fury Swordsman himself wouldn't be difficult. But the Zhongnan Sect stood behind him.

I hated admitting it, but the gap between us and them was vast. For now, it was a gap we could never bridge.

For now.

I had been a perpetual F-rank Hunter, yet I had still made it this far. No one knew what the future held.

Maybe one day, the Jin Family of Taiyuan would stand shoulder to shoulder with the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

Okay, am I getting a little ahead of myself?

It was like the head of some rural township running for President.

I let out a quiet laugh at the thought, and the Roaring Fury Swordsman ground his teeth.

"How dare you laugh at me?"

"My face just naturally looks like it's smiling."

"Shut that mouth of yours!"

The instant his furious shout rang out, Jeok Cheongang's right foot shot forward like lightning and slammed into the Roaring Fury Swordsman's shin.

A Supreme Peak master's joint kick.

Thud!

"Guh!"

"You shut up. How dare a young bastard like you raise his voice in front of an elder?"

"What do you think you're doing?"

"Look at this bastard. I tried to end things nicely, and now you're begging for a beating?"

Wham!

"Urgh!"

Wow. That one really landed.

With an even duller impact than before, the Roaring Fury Swordsman clutched his shin and collapsed.

Even an Elder of the Great Zhongnan Sect is helpless against him.

The man was over sixty and held a lofty position, but his opponent was simply beyond comparison.

Age, martial arts, status—there was no catching up to the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, in any of them.

"Carrying on like that is a disease. You've done enough, so get the hell out of here."

"…Very well."

The Roaring Fury Swordsman glared resentfully at me as he rose, his body covered in dirt. Then Jeok Cheongang's cold voice followed.

"And I will let today's events pass, so you will never speak of this matter again. Do you understand?"

I really should start a fan club.

I had acted on impulse, but the truth was, I had been worried. If the Roaring Fury Swordsman later used the Zhongnan Sect to retaliate, the Jin Family of Taiyuan would have no way to stop him.

But with Jeok Cheongang mediating, things were different.

Though I'm not sure whether to call this mediation or a threat.

Resentment over what had happened today would remain, but at least he wouldn't be able to bring official pressure against us.

Even if he did, having the Fire King as a sturdy shield took a great deal of the pressure off.

"Why aren't you answering?"

The Roaring Fury Swordsman's face twisted horribly now that his little scheme had been seen through. Jeok Cheongang, of course, couldn't have cared less.

"Say it yourself. Right now."

"…Understood. I swear it on my name."

“What name do you have worth staking? Swear it in the name of the Zhongnan Sect.”

“Grrk… Understood.”

Only then did a satisfied smile appear on Jeok Cheongang’s lips. He chuckled and patted the Roaring Fury Swordsman on the shoulder.

“Where did a young bastard like you learn to grind his teeth like that? Maybe I should yank out every last one of them.”

“…”

“Hohoho! But this old man is getting on in years. I couldn’t possibly do such a thing in front of all these people. Hahahaha!”

I had never known that the laughter of a snow-white-haired old man could be so terrifying.

Not only the Roaring Fury Swordsman, but everyone listening flinched at once.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been laughing like a fiend, turned to me.

“You’re not blameless either. Whatever the circumstances, how could you hurl such abuse at an elder so far above you in age? Are you out of your mind?”

I immediately bowed my head. Whatever else had happened, that much was true, and I also thought it was time to settle matters with the Roaring Fury Swordsman, an Elder of the Zhongnan Sect.

“I’m sorry.”

“Even if he ate his age through his asshole, he’s over sixty. It wouldn’t be strange for him to have a grandchild your age.”

“…Ah. Yes.”

“No matter how much of a bastard he is, he’s still your elder and a great Senior of Murim. No matter how filthy and unfair it feels, you must show him the proper respect from now on.”

“Great Hero Song, I sincerely apologize.”

When I straightened from my deep bow, the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s face was flushed scarlet.

Even after receiving an apology, he probably didn’t feel as though he had gotten one.

Meanwhile, despite apologizing to someone I disliked, I felt refreshed, as though I had just circulated my qi.

Is this what comes with age?

Take a look at that verbal skill forged over a hundred years.

He wasn’t just a Supreme Peak master in martial arts. At this point, he could change his title from Fire King to Tongue King.

After completing every step of the settlement under his supervision, the Tongue King announced in a solemn voice,

"All right. Now all the uninvited guests can get the hell out. If you're hungry, have a bowl of rice before you go."

Now he was openly treating them like beggars.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman trembled with humiliation. It was a long while before he finally spoke.

"…Then we will take our leave."

"I won't see you out."

"Let's go!"

As though he had been waiting for those words, the Roaring Fury Swordsman spun around. Gong Ilhyuk and the other two members of the Three Hands of Zhongnan, their faces twisted into ugly grimaces, followed him.

Scorching gazes pursued the backs of the four men. Just before stepping through the main gate, the Roaring Fury Swordsman suddenly turned his head and stared at me.

A thread of Sound Transmission filled with killing intent reached my ears.

— I don't know what connection you have to that old man… but as long as I'm alive, I will definitely punish you and the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

It all happened in the briefest of instants.

The Fire King watched the Roaring Fury Swordsman's back melt into the darkness, his expression unreadable. Then he tossed out a single remark.

"I'll step out for a while."

"Yes? Where are you going?"

"At my age, do I need to report every time I go relieve myself?"

With that gruff reply, he disappeared with a bowlegged gait.

Once he was a good distance from the Jin Family of Taiyuan, the Roaring Fury Swordsman suddenly drew his sword and swung.

Whoooosh! Boom!

Dozens of streams of Sword Energy sliced through trees and shattered rocks. After venting his fury for quite some time, he finally turned it on the Three Hands of Zhongnan, Gong Ilhyuk included.

"You damned idiots…"

"E-Elder."

"Do you know what kind of humiliation this old man suffered because of you?"

"I-I'm sorry. Please forgive your foolish Disciples."

The Three Hands of Zhongnan froze.

Gong Ilhyuk was the most terrified of them all. If he hadn't incited the Roaring Fury Swordsman to come to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, none of this would have happened.

"E-Elder, please calm down and hear me out."

"I turned a blind eye a few times because you're related by marriage to my Junior Brother, the Sect Leader, and now it seems you've forgotten your place."

Clench!

The Roaring Fury Swordsman's gaunt hand closed around Gong Ilhyuk's throat.

"Guh… I-I'm the Sect Leader's…"

"Do you think my Junior Brother, the Sect Leader, would so much as blink if this old man punished the likes of you? You worthless piece of trash."

Gong Ilhyuk's face went deathly pale.

Then—

Thump. Thump. Thud.

His body went limp, his head lolling to one side. The other two members of the Three Hands, who had been frozen with fear, also crumpled helplessly to the ground.

"W-why did these bastards suddenly…"

The Roaring Fury Swordsman, briefly confused, turned his head. He stared intently into the darkness before speaking.

"Do you still have business here?"

"Why else would I have come looking for you?"

Along with that calm voice, a small old man emerged.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

He clicked his tongue as he looked at the fallen Three Hands of Zhongnan.

"Tsk, tsk. Seems I ended up saving those bastards without meaning to. Maybe I should have come a little later."

"Why have you come back?"

"It's been so long. It seemed a shame to let you go just like that."

The Fire King smiled faintly and added,

"There was also something I forgot."

"Something you forgot? What do you mean…"

At that moment, Jeok Cheongang's figure vanished like a phantom.

At the same time, Sword Energy erupted from the Roaring Fury Swordsman's waist.

Sh-sh-sh-sh-shk!

A dense net of Sword Energy spread across a three-jang[1039] radius, slicing through bone and flesh the instant it touched them.

But the big fish had already swum against the current and escaped the net.

“I told you earlier. Don’t touch so much as a hair on that boy’s head.”

Crack!

The sword hilt dropped from the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s hand. His wrist broken, he screamed and drove his knee upward.

“Gyaaah! You fucking old bastard!”

“When will you finally become a proper human being?”

At the same instant, a palm shrouded in pure-white flame pressed against the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s chest.

Boom!

“Guh…!”

An unavoidable palm strike.

His Body-Protecting Qi shattered, and his flesh and bones began to cook. Blood burst from his mouth as he fell to his knees, his eyelids trembling.

“Cough… F-Flame Divine Palm…”

“Raise your head and look at me.”

The old man’s voice was so cold that it made the title Fire King seem meaningless.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman barely managed to lift his head and found himself staring into a pair of eyes where blue ghostly flames flickered.

“F-Fire King.”

“That’s right. This old man is the Fire King.”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman had briefly forgotten just what kind of monster the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, truly was.

Jeok Cheongang had been active in Murim for only a single year in his entire life. Yet with a single battle, he had become a legend and carved his mark into Murim history.

He was an opponent the Roaring Fury Swordsman could never hope to resist.

Deep despair settled over the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s face.

“Are you… are you planning to kill me?”

“If killing you could put an end to everything, this old man would have done it long ago.”

“Then…”

“Remember just one thing.”

The Fire King slowly parted his lips.

[1039] *Jang* is a traditional unit of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Three jang is about 9.09 meters (29.8 ft).

“You may kill Jin Taekyung. You may even wipe out the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and I will stand by and watch. But if that happens, I will go to the Zhongnan Sect.”

“…!”

“I will smash the Zhongnan Sect’s signboard and burn down Mount Zhongnan. If you abandon your main sect and flee, I will chase you to the ends of the earth and kill every last one of you. I will do so until the day my breath stops.”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman’s entire body trembled beneath that terrifying killing intent.

Jeok Cheongang meant every word. He was declaring that he would take on the Zhongnan Sect alone.

If such a thing happened, it was impossible to imagine how many sacrifices would be required.

“What… what am I supposed to do?”

“The choice is yours. The punishment for it belongs to this old man.”

Leaving only those words behind, Jeok Cheongang vanished without a trace.

It was a long while before the Three Hands of Zhongnan finally awoke. They jolted in alarm when they found the Roaring Fury Swordsman sitting there in a daze.

“E-Elder!”

“What happened?”

“Who in the world did this?”

A very long time passed before the Roaring Fury Swordsman finally spoke.

“We’re going back. To Zhongnan.”

His voice was steeped in terror, and the Three Hands of Zhongnan could say nothing.

Chapter 194

"Ahh, that hit the spot."

Jeok Cheongang, who had said he was stepping away for a moment to relieve himself, returned fifteen minutes later. Something felt suspicious, and I narrowed my eyes.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Did you really just go relieve yourself?"

"Do you need to smell me before you'll believe me?"

"But it took you fifteen minutes. Could it be that—"

"This old man has virility to spare."

"…"

How virile did you have to be to spend fifteen minutes pissing?

At that point, it wasn't a stream. It was a fire hose.

When I stared at him in disbelief, Jeok Cheongang glared at me.

"What? You got a problem?"

"Of course not."

A problem? Me?

Considering all the help he had given me today, I could bow to him a hundred times and it still wouldn't be enough.

And then there's the other thing…

I pushed aside the thought that had suddenly occurred to me.

The Fire Gate Clan's divine artifact. The Fire King's Disciple.

I also pretended not to hear the voices that had been whispering nonstop ever since.

Disciple? That's ridiculous.

It was something I had never once considered before.

Why would a man accept as his new Disciple someone he had known for only a day—someone who had killed the Disciple he had cherished like a son?

Even if that Disciple had been a colossal son of a bitch.

As I was thinking about it, Jin Wikyung approached and respectfully cupped his hands toward Jeok Cheongang.

"I, Jin Wikyung, a junior of Murim, pay my respects to the Fire King Jeok Cheongang, whose fame resounds throughout the world."

"Are you from the Jin Family?"

Jeok Cheongang looked Jin Wikyung up and down, then nodded as if he had figured it out.

"Then you're this brat's father?"

"What?"

"Raise your son properly. The boy's young, but he's already hotheaded and causing trouble. His manners are terrible, too."

Jin Wikyung answered with the darkest expression I had ever seen on his face.

"…"

"He's my younger brother."

"Hm?"

"I'm Taekyung's eldest brother."

Jeok Cheongang's face turned serious.

"Don't joke around. I understand wanting to look young, but if you get too greedy, Heaven will punish you."

"It's the truth. I am Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"…"

"How old are you, by any chance?"

"Now that the year has turned, I'm thirty-six."

Jeok Cheongang muttered in disbelief.

"You look forty-six."

Admittedly, his face was somewhat—quite a lot, actually—more weathered than his age suggested. Even I had mistaken him for my father at first.

At least his hair was still thick, but there was no cure for a face that had taken a 160-kilometer-per-hour[1040] fastball from time itself.

Seeing the sadness on Jin Wikyung's face, Jeok Cheongang tried to comfort him.

"It's all right. What matters in a man is his ability. You've got a pretty wife and adorable children, so what more do you need? Heh heh."

"I'm still single."

"…At thirty-six?"

In modern times, that would only be around the age when people started thinking seriously about marriage. But in Murim, where early marriage was common, thirty-six was old enough to have grandchildren.

The bachelor Jin Wikyung gave a terse answer.

"Yes."

"…"

This silence ran a little long. The Fire King furrowed his brow, relaxed it, then flared his nostrils before finally heaving a deep sigh.

"Damn it. I could really use a drink."

[1040] 160 kilometers per hour is about 99 miles per hour.

I let out a quiet laugh. It was a feast day, after all. What kind of feast would it be without alcohol? There was alcohol everywhere.

"Would you like a drink?"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened.

"You insolent brat. Are you making fun of this old man?"

"What?"

"Bring me the whole crock."

A mood was like a spark. Once it went out, it was difficult to rekindle.

Yet even after the uninvited guests from the Zhongnan Sect had poured cold water over everything, the spark had not died.

No—in the presence of the Fire King, it blazed even more fiercely.

"Wooooo!"

"Drink! Come on, let's drink!"

"I never thought I'd live to see the Fire King in person!"

"When the Fire King gets flustered, he goes Left Fire King, Right Fire King![1041]"

"…"

I didn't know who that was, but that bastard had nearly put out the spark just now.

At my signal, Hyuk Mujin, who had been standing by, quietly slipped away to hunt down the mood killer.

Meanwhile, Jeok Cheongang was receiving greetings from countless people.

"Great Hero Jeok! It's the honor of a lifetime to meet you!"

"Please do us the honor of visiting our sect sometime…"

"Please grant us your guidance!"

It was truly a sea of people.

The name of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was practically synonymous with living legend.

Moreover, his whereabouts had been unknown for decades, so most people had long accepted his death as fact.

And now the Fire King, whom everyone had thought dead, had appeared—not in the Central Plains or on Mount Jiuhua, but right here at the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Shanxi Province.

Of course everyone's going to lose their minds.

[1041] This plays on *jwa-wang-u-wang*, a Korean expression for being flustered or acting in confusion. The joke inserts *hwa* ("fire") before each *wang* ("king").

Perhaps this was what it would be like if the legendary singer once called the Emperor of Pop came back from the dead.

Yet despite the enthusiasm of his local Shanxi fans, Michael Cheongang looked thoroughly displeased.

Jin Wikyung seemed to notice, too, and sent me a Sound Transmission.

—My youngest.

The only people who could hold a lengthy conversation with the eccentric Jeok Cheongang were Cheongpung and me. But there was no telling where Cheongpung's thoughts might wander, so in the end, I had no choice but to act as the messenger.

"Are you uncomfortable?"

"Look at the state I'm in. Wouldn't you be uncomfortable if you were me?"

Jeok Cheongang glared at the wine crock beside him. Quite a bit of time had passed, yet hardly any of it was gone.

It wasn't that he disliked alcohol. He simply hadn't had time to drink.

"Damn it. It shouldn't be this hard to have a single drink."

People kept asking him to accept them as Disciples, while Sect Leaders and merchants begged to host him as an honored guest.

One heavily pregnant woman had even asked if she could touch his nose. She wanted to receive the Fire King's qi so she could give birth to a great person, or something like that.

Was he a dol hareubang or something?[1042]

It was enough to make even the onlookers snicker. How much worse must it have been for the man at the center of it all?

Frankly, given Jeok Cheongang's personality, the fact that he had endured this much was impressive in itself.

"Why don't we move somewhere I prepared in advance? It's quiet there."

"Ugh. Forget it."

"You said you were uncomfortable."

"I said forget it. Why are you so damn talkative?"

Even while grumbling, Jeok Cheongang stubbornly refused to leave. I tilted my head.

What's going on?

We had known each other for only a short time, but I had gotten a fairly good sense of his personality.

It was obvious that he hated noisy places and found people's attention bothersome. That was probably why he had spent his entire life on Mount Jiuhua.

[1042] A *dol hareubang* is a stone guardian statue from Jeju Island. Folk beliefs associate touching its nose with fertility.

Then why?

I watched Jeok Cheongang carefully.

In front of him, the owner of a merchant association with considerable influence in Shanxi Province was bowing and scraping.

“Great Hero Jeok! I’ve long heard of your reputation, which shakes the entire world. When I was young, I admired you so much…”

“Get to the point.”

“I have always admired you from the bottom of my heart, so I prepared a small token of my sincerity.”

“A small token?”

“Yes. It’s something I acquired recently, but I suppose every item has its destined owner.”

The merchant took a small wooden box from inside his robe and opened the lid. Inside was a ring set with clear jade.

“It is a Poison-Averting Ring.”

“A fairly valuable item. It must have been difficult to obtain.”

The merchant waved his hands dramatically.

“Having the honor of seeing your noble face, how could price possibly matter? It only cost a thousand silver nyang.[1043] Heh heh.”

A thousand silver nyang[1044] for a single ring. It ranked among the most expensive gifts the Jin Family of Taiyuan had received so far.

Jeok Cheongang, however, merely nodded without much interest.

“Well, since you’re giving it to me, I’ll accept it gratefully. Who are you, and where are you from?”

“I’m in charge of the Yangcheon Merchant Association…”

“Yangcheon? That’s near Hebei.”

The merchant had been interrupted before he could even give his name, but he bowed as if he had received a great honor.

“Yes. We are trying to begin trading with the Hebei Peng Family, but it has not been easy.”

That was the merchant’s real purpose.

It was why he had sought out Jeok Cheongang even after offering a token of sincerity that was anything but small.

In short, he wanted Jeok Cheongang to help him establish a business relationship with the Hebei Peng Family.

“The Peng Family, huh? Who’s the Family Head these days?”

“It is Great Hero Peng Cheolyeong, the Iron Blood Saber.”

[1043] A *nyang* was a historical Korean currency unit; the amount here is a thousand silver nyang.

[1044] A *nyang* was a historical Korean currency unit; the amount here is a thousand silver nyang.

“I’ve never heard of him. Is he the Thunderbolt Saber King’s son?”

“Yes, yes. The Thunderbolt Saber King retired from the front lines and passed the position of Family Head to him.”

“This old man once had a drink with the Thunderbolt Saber King in his younger days. All right, I understand.”

That was the end of the conversation. The merchant set down the wooden box and left with a grin stretching from ear to ear.

Beneath the box lay a stack of bank drafts that had not been there moments ago.

I took advantage of the merchant’s retreat to whisper to Jeok Cheongang.

“You know the Thunderbolt Saber King?”

As his title suggested, the Thunderbolt Saber King was one of the Ten Kings, a Supreme Peak master just like Jeok Cheongang.

Jeok Cheongang took a sip of wine before answering.

“I told you. We had a drink together.”

“Wow.”

He talked about the Thunderbolt Saber King as if he were some old neighborhood friend. Every time he did something like this, I was reminded all over again of just how extraordinary Jeok Cheongang was.

When I gaped at him in admiration, Jeok Cheongang puffed out his chest.

“I flattened that bastard’s nose years ago.”

“…What?”

“I was having a drink with the Sword Saint when he barged in without a word and picked a fight. We fought, and I taught him a lesson.”

What the hell was he talking about?

“Weren’t you two friends?”

“Me? With that guy?”

Jeok Cheongang furrowed his brow.

“Why would I associate with an uncultured bastard like him? We never saw each other again after that.”

“…”

“Later, some strange rumor even started going around. They said the Peng Family’s man and I had exchanged over a hundred moves before acknowledging each other and withdrawing. The bastards from the Hebei Peng Family must have pulled some kind of trick.”

I was dumbfounded, and so was everyone around me.

The story about the Thunderbolt Saber King was absurd enough, but if it was true, the merchant’s request had just gone up in smoke.

“Th-then the Yangcheon Merchant Association won’t be able to trade with the Hebei Peng Family, will they? Mentioning Great Hero Jeok’s name will only make things worse.”

Jeok Cheongang blinked.

“The Yangcheon Merchant Association? What’s that?”

“…”

“Ah, you mean that guy from earlier? Why should I care about him?”

“But you said you’d help him trade with the Hebei Peng Family.”

“He asked me to meet him, so I met him. It’s also true that I had a drink with the Thunderbolt Saber King. Was there even a shred of falsehood in anything this old man said?”

“…”

I wasn’t sure about that, but he certainly didn’t seem to possess even a shred of conscience.

His shamelessness was so impressive that I almost respected him for it.

Fire King, are you even human?

He had more than one or two victims. Before long, the people who had believed Jeok Cheongang’s empty promises and offered him a “small token of sincerity” would realize that it had all been complete bullshit and pound the ground in despair.

At this point, this is organized fraud.

Not that any of the victims would come forward.

No one was brave enough to approach the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, and demand their gifts back.

“We would be honored if you would visit our sect sometime…”

“Hmm. I’ll stop by one day.”

Meaning after he died and found himself wandering the netherworld.

“This is my small token of sincerity…”

“I’ll accept it.”

No. He really is just taking it.

As I watched the treasures, elixirs, and bank drafts pile up like a mountain, I finally realized something.

Was this why he stayed?

It was clearly a grand plan to make one big haul in his old age.

Eventually, after dealing with dozens of suckers, Jeok Cheongang spoke.

“Hmm. This is quite a haul. Aren’t there any more?”

Jin Wikyung answered with an exhausted expression.

“Yes. It seems that everyone who was likely to come has already arrived.”

"A shame. I could have squeezed more out of them."

Just look at the greed on this old man.

Jeok Cheongang gazed at the spoils he had earned by drinking instead of sweating, then stretched his arms high above his head.

"Good grief, this is tiring."

"…"

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

I subtly averted my gaze from Jeok Cheongang's round eyes.

"It's nothing. I was just admiring you."

"From where I'm standing, that doesn't look like admiration."

"I'm serious. There's nothing wrong with having a lot of wealth."

"Is that so?"

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh, then casually tossed out a remark.

"Then you take it."

"What?"

"I'm saying I'll give all of it to you."

"All of that?"

"It's completely useless to this old man, but it's different for you. Scatter it in the street or do whatever you want with it. I won't care, so take it."

What was going on?

I stared at Jeok Cheongang in bewilderment.

Why all of a sudden?

He had already helped me immensely. Naturally, I couldn't help wondering why he was showing such extraordinary favor to both me and the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Could it really be what I thought? Could he truly mean it?

I swallowed dryly and opened my mouth.

"Great Hero Jeok, by any chance…"

At that moment, Jeok Cheongang rose from his seat and spoke with a drunken expression.

"Ahh, I'm drunk. I'm going inside to rest. See you tomorrow."

"…"

I watched Jeok Cheongang stagger away, then turned my gaze back to the wine crock.

The moon was reflected in the crock, which he had not even emptied a quarter of.

Chapter 195

Calling the banquet held on New Year's Day a resounding success still felt like an understatement.

By embracing the Mount Heng Sword Sect, Jin Wikyung had made a bold move that won the loyalty of dozens of small and mid-sized sects. The Zhongnan Sect's intervention and the appearance of Fire King Jeok Cheongang, whom everyone had believed dead, had left them all stunned.

And…

I was one of them.

I ate, drank, and moved from place to place. Wherever I went, people's eyes followed my every move.

Half a day ago, those gazes had meant interest in the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

Not anymore.

The Fire King's Disciple. The heir to the Fire Gate Clan.

I heard those words everywhere. People talked endlessly about what it meant that Jeok Cheongang, the current Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan, had entrusted me with the sect's sacred treasure—and why he had protected the Jin Family of Taiyuan even at the cost of making an enemy of the Zhongnan Sect.

This already seems to be half-confirmed as fact.

To be honest, I didn't understand Jeok Cheongang's intentions either.

That was why I was here.

Everyone was still distracted, and I had managed to slip away unnoticed. This was my chance.

"Phew."

I took a deep breath.

I stood before the pavilion where Jeok Cheongang had been given lodging. Someone must have ordered everyone to stay away, because there wasn't so much as a mouse near the large building.

"Great Hero Jeok. Are you there?"

A reply came from beyond the door.

"I'm sleeping."

"I came because there's something I wanted to ask you."

"I said I'm sleeping."

"…How are you answering me if you're asleep?"

"I'm sleepwalking."

Was that an answer or a whinny?

It made no sense, but if the Fire King said that was how it was, then that was how it was. I pulled myself together and tried again.

"Um, there's something I can't stop wondering about."

"Is this old man responsible for satisfying your curiosity?"

"No, but…"

"If you know that, go wash your feet and get some sleep."

Talk about an impenetrable defense.

But I couldn't back down now.

I began creeping ever so carefully toward the firmly closed door.

"Take one more step, and you won't live to see tomorrow's sunrise."

"…How did you know?"

"To this old man, your presence is no different from a clap of thunder."

"Come on. Couldn't you let me in now? It's still winter, and it's rather chilly out here."

"Would you like this old man to warm you up with the Flame Divine Palm?"

"…"

Just hearing that made my insides feel warm.

When I shut my mouth, silence fell. After a while, Jeok Cheongang broke it with a single sentence.

"I went to Jeongyang."

"Ah."

Even an insignificant bead could hold special meaning for someone. Jeongyang was like that.

Jeongyang was merely one of the dozens of counties and towns in Shanxi Province, but Jeok Cheongang had a reason to visit a mountain path there.

Jopil.

On the day snow came pouring from the sky, a man who had lived as Jangcheon died under the name Jopil.

"I stayed for a long time at the place you told me about. Some passersby saw an old man wandering around the foot of the mountain and asked why I was there."

His subdued voice continued.

"I told them that a blood relative had died right there. That I had come because I wanted to recover whatever remained of his body."

"…"

"That was when I realized something. Even if I had met that boy before you did, I could never have killed him. I would have let him go again, only to regret it afterward."

It was difficult to imagine what expression Jeok Cheongang wore on the other side of the door.

After hesitating, I asked, “Did you find his body?”

“Nothing was left.”

Several months had already passed.

Jopil had spent his entire life walking a path of blood. The subordinates who might have recovered his body had died alongside him, so whatever remained had likely been buried by the capricious weather or devoured by hungry beasts.

“It is nothing but an old man’s selfish desire. Ugly and futile.”

Glug.

The sound of liquor filling a cup seemed unusually loud.

“I thought you said you were drunk earlier.”

“You crafty brat. Why ask when you already know?”

The candlelight flooding the pavilion outlined his silhouette.

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh, then tossed back his drink.

“Ahh. Good.”

His voice sounded refreshed, as though that one cup had washed away his troubles.

It occurred to me that Jeok Cheongang had gone to the place where Jopil died to free himself from the regret and lingering attachment that still held him.

I deliberately brightened my voice.

“I was taught that good things should be shared.”

“I was taught from a young age that anyone who coveted what belonged to others should be burned with the Flame Divine Palm.”

“What terrifying person taught you that?”

“My Master.”

That was the Volcano Gate Clan for you. Ruthless.

They burned everyone with the Flame Divine Palm, no matter who it was.

I didn’t know the history of the Fire Gate Clan or the names of its past Sect Leaders, but looking at Jeok Cheongang, I could make a rough guess.

An old sect of thugs.

They said beans grew where beans were planted and red beans where red beans were planted.

Like master, like disciple. Jopil was the exception, of course.

Anyway, this isn’t what I came here to talk about.

I was watching the silhouette inside the pavilion while trying to read the situation when Jeok Cheongang suddenly spoke.

“From now on, the Fire Heaven Sword is yours.”

“Fire… what?”

“The Fire Heaven Sword. The sword I entrusted to you.”

I had just learned the Unnamed Sword's true name, but that wasn't the issue right now. I was so shocked that I stammered.

"B-but that's the Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure."

"Ah, the sacred treasure."

Jeok Cheongang tipped back yet another cup of liquor before continuing.

"That was a lie."

"What?"

"It isn't a sacred treasure. One of our sect's Sect Leaders used it about a hundred years ago, and later generations inherited it from him. It's old, but it was already renowned as a divine weapon back then, so it should still be useful."

"…!"

What the hell was he talking about?

I stood there with my mouth hanging open at this shocking truth I had never expected.

"That was all a lie? You're messing with me, right?"

"Messing with you? Why would I bother with a little pup like you?"

"You said it in front of everyone! 'I entrusted that boy with the Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure!'"

"I did. Because we were in front of everyone."

Jeok Cheongang continued in an indifferent voice.

"I had to go that far to get people talking. 'That boy must have a deep connection to the Fire King. Perhaps he is the Fire King's Disciple, since he was entrusted with the sacred treasure. If anyone touches the Jin Family of Taiyuan, that terrifying Fire King will step in.' Rumors like that will spread far and wide."

"…"

"Do you really think this old man would entrust our sect's sacred treasure to a young brat like you? Our arts are passed down to only one successor per generation, so no one else knows the truth. If I say it is a sacred treasure, then it is a sacred treasure."

"…"

"So keep the sword. That way, those Zhongnan bastards won't dare make a move."

Is this a dream?

As I stood there in shock, a System notification rang in my ears, delivering the final blow.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Information regarding the Unnamed Sword has been updated.
Item Window
Fire Heaven Sword
Type: Sword
Grade: Peak
Restriction: One who has inherited the Fire Gate Clan's legacy
Description: The beloved sword once used by the Fire Gate Clan's tenth Sect Leader. Forged from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, it is exceptionally sharp and durable. After passing through the hands of countless owners over many years, it changed of its own accord. Only one who has inherited the Fire Gate Clan's legacy can draw out its true power.
Effect: Unknown

The updated information was exactly as Jeok Cheongang had said.

It was the beloved sword of the tenth Sect Leader. No matter how hard I looked, there wasn't a single mention of it being the Fire Gate Clan's sacred treasure.

Even the "true power" hidden within the sword could only be drawn out by someone who had inherited the Fire Gate Clan's legacy.

In other words, other than the fact that it was made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, the sword was a corpse.

I really thought it was a sacred treasure. I spent so much time worrying about what I'd do if he said he wanted to make me his Disciple…

As I stared blankly at the holographic window, Jeok Cheongang added as though he were doing me a great favor.

"Think of it as a long-term loan. If this old man forgets about it and dies, you may keep it. Ah, and hand over the Flame Divine Palm manual right now."

"Damn old man… Gasp."

I had only meant to think it, but the words slipped out of my mouth.

I clapped my mouth shut in alarm. At that very moment, the firmly closed pavilion door burst outward.

Crack!

A pair of eyes blazing with fire glared at me.

"You little pup. What did you just say?"

"I-I-I misspoke."

"Misspoke? Then this old man will make a little mistake with his hand, too."

Whoosh!

A palm glowed red-hot, radiating overwhelming heat.

I spun around without looking back. In the same instant, I pulled the Flame Divine Palm manual from my Inventory and threw it.

“Gasp! The manual! The Flame Divine Palm manual!”

If he reached out now, the manual would turn to ash.

Jeok Cheongang, startled, hastily pulled back his fist. I took advantage of the opening and ran with all my might.

“I’m sorry! I’m really sorry! Please spare me!”

“You damned bastard! Stop right there!”

His roar thundered behind me.

Jeok Cheongang watched Jin Taekyung flee as though his tail were on fire and let out a quiet laugh.

The anger that had filled his face only moments ago had vanished without a trace.

“You little fool. No matter how far you run, you are still in the palm of this old man’s hand.”

He could catch Taekyung whenever he wished.

But Jeok Cheongang merely clasped his hands behind his back and turned away.

Jin Taekyung had killed Jangcheon, the Disciple Jeok Cheongang had cherished like a son.

Yet Jeok Cheongang bore him no hatred.

If anything, Taekyung was one of the people to whom Jeok Cheongang owed a sincere apology.

Everything had begun with the wrong choice Jeok Cheongang had made ten years ago.

“He called me a damn old man.”

Despite being cursed by a little pup, Jeok Cheongang wasn’t offended.

No, if anything, he felt relieved.

“That’s right. I am a damn old man. A senile old man, too. Heh heh. Heh heh heh.”

After his Master died, no one had dared criticize or curse Jeok Cheongang to his face.

He was the Fire King, a great martial artist who had single-handedly written himself into legend.

And yet, hearing that one remark from Jin Taekyung made him feel as though something that had been blocked for a long time had suddenly burst open.

“How refreshing. Truly refreshing.”

As people grow older, they become lonelier day by day. Not because they have no one with whom to share their warmth, but because they have no one to lean on.

Jeok Cheongang could serve as someone else's support, but he had grown too old to lean on anyone himself.

"To be someone's support…"

Jeok Cheongang was a rough, sharp thorn tree. He had lived a long life and crossed paths with countless people, but he had never allowed anyone to lean on him.

There had been only one exception.

Jangcheon.

"What about you? Did you ever feel, even for a moment, that this Master was a dependable support?"

As Jeok Cheongang thought of him, his gaze clouded over. But his chest no longer hurt as much as it once had, nor did his eyes grow hot.

The dead had already returned to a handful of earth.

At the place where his Disciple had fallen in a spray of blood, Jeok Cheongang had drunk a bottle of liquor and poured out an entire crockful.

He had wept freely, shedding the tears he had been unable to shed for the past ten years and letting the grief in his heart flow out with them.

"I'm sorry. Today will be the last time I think of you."

If there was to be a next time, it would be in the next life.

He might still think of his dead Disciple from time to time. But those thoughts would no longer be regrets about the past.

They would be memories.

"This is enough. This is how it should be."

After pacing around the courtyard for a long while, Jeok Cheongang suddenly stopped.

The image of Jangcheon that had been flickering before his eyes vanished, replaced by someone he had never expected to think of.

Why him?

Open, well-defined features. A confident smile that somehow managed to be irritating.

The way he cautiously gauged Jeok Cheongang's mood, yet still took every cutting remark in stride.

Did I get angry without realizing it because he called me a damn old man?

Jeok Cheongang was frowning when—

Sizzle.

The sound of something burning filled the air, followed by a thin trail of smoke.

Realizing where the sound had come from, his eyes flew open.

"Th-the manual!"

The cover of the Flame Divine Palm manual was already half-burned.
Jeok Cheongang let out a furious roar.
“Jin Taekyung! You damned bastard!”

Chapter 196

“W-What happened here?”

A middle-aged merchant—the third generation of his family to run a textile shop in the center of Taiyuan, Shanxi Province—stood with his mouth hanging open.

“T-The silk…”

The bolts of silk that should have filled the shop had vanished without a trace. Various furnishings lay broken, and the proprietor, who should have been busy welcoming customers, was sprawled on the floor, drenched in sweat.

“Thieves! We’ve been robbed!”

The merchant’s vision went dark, and the strength drained from his legs.

He already operated several textile shops, but this was his largest store in Taiyuan, the flagship passed down from his grandfather and a symbol of his family’s legacy.

And someone had robbed it. Every last bolt of silk was gone!

I knew things had been going too well.

For the past four months, the merchant had traveled from province to province, inspecting his stores and closing a major contract.

Yet after all that time away, he had returned to find his flagship store in ruins. Unable to withstand the shock, he sank to the floor.

That was when—

“Tsk, tsk. This place is a mess, too. Honestly, martial artists…”

A middle-aged man had been clicking his tongue as he looked around the shop. When he noticed the merchant sitting on the floor, his eyes widened.

“Oh? When did you get back? I heard you had a big deal to close this time. You’re back earlier than I expected.”

But the merchant was already half out of his mind. He heard none of it except for one word that kept echoing in his ears.

“H-Here, too?”

“Huh?”

The merchant seized the middle-aged man by the collar and shook him violently.

“You said this place was a mess, too!”

“Y-Yeah, I did. But could you let go of my collar while we talk?”

“What happened? Mounted bandits? Thieves? Did a war break out and the authorities requisition everything? And what do martial artists have to do with it?”

“I said let go of me first!”

The middle-aged man finally tore himself free, then inspected his clothes with a grumble.

“Damn it. These are new.”

“If you don’t tell me right now, you’ll die and I’ll die with you.”

“All right, all right.”

“So what happened?”

The middle-aged man’s answer was simple.

“It all sold.”

“…What?”

“We weren’t robbed. It’s gone because everything sold out, my friend. So get a grip.”

The merchant stared blankly at him before finally managing to speak.

“Have you lost your mind? How does that make any sense? Who would buy more than a thousand bolts of silk?”

“Government officials, merchants, martial artists. Every last one of them came rushing in and cleaned the place out.”

“…Why?”

“Why do you think? They all want to make an impression on the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan? The one I know?”

“Of course the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Who else? The Mount Heng Sword Sect?”

“Why are you bringing up the Mount Heng Sword Sect? Did something happen?”

“…You really haven’t heard?”

“I just got back after four months. I came straight here without even seeing my wife!”

“W-Wait! Please calm down. I’ll tell you everything.”

Not wanting his new clothes ruined, the middle-aged man gave him a quick summary of everything that had happened over the past few months.

Fifteen minutes later, after hearing the whole story from the war between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect to the present day, the merchant muttered in a daze.

“All that happened?”

“I told you. Shanxi is in an uproar over the Fire King’s arrival. And it isn’t just Shanxi Province. The city is crawling with outsiders who came to meet him.”

The middle-aged man continued, his face flushed with excitement.

“I’ve been doing business in Taiyuan for over twenty years, but I’ve never seen a boom like this.”

“For all that, the streets didn’t look any busier than usual…”

“Do you think people would still be loitering in the streets when the sun has been high in the sky for hours? They packed up their things ages ago and ran to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

"Good heavens. It's hard to believe."

"I even cleared out my entire stock."

"A-Already?"

"Why are you so surprised? Mine was nothing compared to yours. And I heard this next part from someone reliable…"

The middle-aged man lowered his voice to a conspiratorial whisper.

"The gathering was originally supposed to last three days, but it may be extended. The rumors are spreading fast, and the real big shots are beginning to move."

"The real big shots?"

"The Murim's prestigious major sects have started mobilizing. Seok Family Manor, said to be foremost in the merchant world, and His Highness Prince Shangshan, the City Lord, both went to the Jin Family of Taiyuan early this morning."

"Even His Highness Prince Shangshan?"

"That's why those officials who usually drag their feet are scrambling now. A member of the imperial family is coming. They have to show their faces and offer some token of sincerity, don't they?"

"Of course. And they'd better arrive before everyone else."

"What kind of place is Taiyuan? It may not rival the Central Plains, but it's unquestionably the greatest commercial city in Shanxi Province. You can buy almost anything here."

"Local procurement. I see."

"And the more people come looking for something, the scarcer it'll become. Prices will rise, too."

The merchant's eyes flashed. He had realized this would not end in a day or two.

His earlier confusion and despair had already vanished. Now mountains of silver nyang[1045] danced before his eyes.

This is an opportunity.

He could establish connections with people from the Murim, the merchant world, and the government. If he played his cards right, he might land an enormous deal.

After finishing his calculations, the merchant turned to the middle-aged man.

"I filled several warehouses just in case. I'll let you have part of the stock at a reasonable price, so tell me straight. Who should I approach?"

Having just found his chance to make a killing, the middle-aged man grinned broadly.

"First, remember three people: the Fire King, Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung."

"…The Fire King and the Lesser Family Head, I understand. But why that good-for-nothing Jin Taekyung?"

[1045] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency. A silver nyang denotes its value in silver.

“Hey now. He’s the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi these days. Before long, he’ll become an incredible master capable of influencing the entire world.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Tsk, tsk. How can a merchant be this completely out of touch?”

The middle-aged man savored the merchant’s bewildered expression. At last, he revealed the fact he had saved for this very moment.

“The Fire King has taken the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi as his Disciple.”

“What? Is that true?”

“I told you it was. Two days ago, an Elder of the Zhongnan Sect who didn’t know about it caused a scene, then went back after getting thoroughly beaten. He even entrusted the Sleeping Dragon with his sect’s divine artifact.”

“Th-Then…”

“It wouldn’t be an exaggeration to say that half the people heading to the Jin Family of Taiyuan right now are going to make an impression on the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, not the Fire King.”

The Fire King was unquestionably one of the greatest Supreme Peak masters in the world, but he was old—very old—and had no real power base to speak of.

Jin Taekyung was different.

He was only twenty-one, possessed outstanding martial talent, and had the powerful Jin Family of Taiyuan behind him.

No, wait.

It was the other way around now. The Jin Family of Taiyuan had gained an extraordinary source of support.

They now had the renowned Fire King, as well as Jin Taekyung, who might one day grow into a Supreme Peak master comparable to his teacher.

The merchant’s face flushed with excitement.

“It’s like giving wings to a tiger.”

“So we have to climb aboard before it flies away.”

This was an opportunity worth staking his entire fortune on.

Having finally made up his mind, the merchant spoke.

“I need to meet the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi at once.”

“That’s the right answer. But right now, you’d have trouble meeting him even if you showed up carrying a fortune in gold.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know. According to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, he suddenly entered closed-door cultivation[1046].”

[1046] Closed-door cultivation is secluded martial training undertaken without visitors or other distractions.

“Closed-door cultivation[1047]? That thing martial artists do? Why now, of all times?”

The middle-aged man let out a deep sigh.

“Exactly. I hear the Heaven Shaking Sword has also shut himself away, muttering about enlightenment or something.”

“Good heavens. Isn’t there any way around this?”

“I don’t know. Things have grown too big too quickly. The Jin Family of Taiyuan is practically bursting at the seams, so it seems they’ve started being selective about whom they let in.”

“Didn’t you say you were fairly close with one of the Jin Family’s Squad Leaders? I heard you slipped him a few bribes, too.”

“He’s dead. He died in the last war.”

“Oh dear.”

With powerful figures from every sphere already on the move, it would not be easy for ordinary merchants like them to get involved.

The two men put their heads together and racked their brains until the merchant suddenly spoke.

“I do know someone over there.”

“Oh! Someone you know well?”

“I know him very well. He’s a boy my wife gave birth to.”

The middle-aged man frowned at the merchant’s answer.

They had known each other long enough to be intimately familiar with each other’s family affairs.

“You mean your eldest son?”

“That’s right. That unfilial bastard hasn’t shown his face once in years. Judging by the fact that my wife hasn’t said anything, he must still be alive somehow…”

The middle-aged man nodded, plainly disappointed.

“Well, this is as good a time as any to contact him. Who knows? He might be making a name for himself as a proper martial artist.”

The merchant let out a derisive laugh.

“The son of a textile merchant, a martial artist? As if. He’s probably waiting hand and foot on someone.”

“If that someone happens to be the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, wouldn’t that be a good thing?”

“Impossible. If it turns out to be true, then from this day forward, my family name won’t be Hyuk. It’ll be Gyeon—gyeon as in dog!”

[1047] Closed-door cultivation is secluded martial training undertaken without visitors or other distractions.

"Achoo!"

With the sound of a sneeze, my back suddenly felt cool.

Lying facedown on the bed with my upper body bare, I spoke quietly.

"Mujin, do you want to die?"

Hyuk Mujin, who had been wiping my back with a cloth soaked in cold water, answered.

"Oh, I'm sorry. My nose suddenly started itching."

"Do that one more time. It'll be the last sneeze of your life."

"…Yes, sir."

"Good. Keep wiping."

Swish. Swish.

Every pass of the cold cloth across my back sent a dull throb of pain through me.

That was only natural. My entire upper body was covered in black-and-blue bruises.

Damn it. It's been two days, and I'm still like this.

This had never happened before. Until now, I had recovered from most injuries in no time with sleep mode and by circulating my qi.

Every time I leveled up, I had poured points into Muscles and Bones and Sinews and Meridians. Ordinary blows shouldn't have been able to damage me.

But…

That's a Supreme Peak master for you.

None of it meant a damn thing against the Fire King.

He had been quiet for ages, only to suddenly chase me down and beat me senseless. He hadn't even used the Flame Divine Palm, but every punch from his bare fists had felt as though my flesh and bones were being ripped apart.

The next thing I knew, I was waking up in unimaginable pain in the Jin Family of Taiyuan's infirmary. After they moved me back to my pavilion, I spent the next two days confined to bed.

"That damn old man."

"Gasp!"

Hyuk Mujin sucked in a sharp breath.

"Captain, have you lost your mind? He'll really kill you."

"Let him. What are people outside saying?"

"Officially, we've settled on calling it closed-door cultivation[1048]. It would be rather bad if rumors spread that the Fire King beat up the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

"What about my eldest brother?"

[1048] Closed-door cultivation is secluded martial training undertaken without visitors or other distractions.

“Would the Lesser Family Head have any other choice? After hearing the initial report, he got extremely angry for a moment and went to see Great Hero Jeok, but…”

“He went to see him?”

“He saw the burned Flame Divine Palm manual, apologized several times, and left.”

“What did he have to apologize for? Did I set it on fire? Jeok Cheongang did that himself. And did he really have to beat me this badly over a little singeing?”

“I caught a glimpse of it, and it was more than a little singed. Almost half the cover with the title on it had burned away. The Flame Divine Palm had become just the Flame.”

“…”

“Anyway, I think we should stop talking about this. I don’t know about you, Captain, but I’m terrified. If Great Hero Jeok suddenly walks in, we’re both dead, aren’t we?”

“That’s true.”

Hyuk Mujin’s foresight was remarkable. Barely a moment after he finished speaking, the door flew open.

“Gasp!”

“Guh!”

“…You bastards. What was that reaction?”

“N-Nothing.”

The small, elderly man, Jeok Cheongang, narrowed his eyes and looked at us. Then he snorted.

“Fine. Since this old man didn’t hear anything, I’ll let it slide this once.”

Surprisingly willing to let the matter go, he jerked his chin at Hyuk Mujin.

“You, get out. You’re in the way.”

I didn’t know what he intended to do, but I had a feeling I would be better off with Hyuk Mujin in the room.

Hyuk Mujin responded to my desperate gaze—the gaze of a man who wanted to live a long life.

“Yes, sir. I’ll take my leave. Good luck!”

“Very well.”

…Son of a bitch.

Hyuk Mujin scurried out, leaving me consumed by anxiety.

There was something ominous about the way Jeok Cheongang was staring at my bare upper body.

“Wh-What is it?”

Surely not.

But Jeok Cheongang's eyes gleamed with an inexplicable heat.

"Take off your pants."

"Gasp. Wh-What do you mean?"

"Strip. Don't leave a single scrap of cloth on your body."

I desperately covered my chest. My voice trembled with shame and fear.

"B-But there's someone I like."

"…What does that have to do with anything?"

What a Western mindset!

I was screwed. There was no way out.

As I froze in place, Jeok Cheongang shouted:

"Ah, I'm going to cleanse your sinews and wash your marrow[1049], so take off your clothes and lie down already!"

"…"

You should've said so from the start.

[1049] Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow is a martial-arts concept of improving a person's physical constitution.

Chapter 197

Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow.

The name literally meant shedding one's hair and cleansing one's bones and muscles. It was a procedure performed only by prestigious sects with long histories.

By using internal energy to reshape the bones and muscles and purge the waste accumulated within the body, it transformed a person's constitution into one better suited to learning martial arts.

Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow had to be performed steadily over multiple sessions. The problem was that both the requirements and the process were extremely demanding.

After hearing Jeok Cheongang's explanation, I asked, "Is it really that difficult?"

Jeok Cheongang nodded.

"You're artificially changing the body you were born with. Did you really think that would be easy and convenient? If it were, there wouldn't be anyone in this world who wasn't a master."

Fair enough.

An ordinary person had to grit their teeth and work out for months just to carve out a six-pack.

Changing your very bones, muscles, and constitution would obviously be far more difficult.

"Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow requires three things."

He said it was incredibly difficult, but there are only three?

That thought vanished the instant Jeok Cheongang continued.

"First, an internal-energy master with at least two jiazi of internal energy."

"…Yikes."

The difficulty level was brutal right from the start.

Two jiazi amounted to a full one hundred and twenty years. How many people under heaven could possibly possess that much internal energy?

There had to be very few, and Jeok Cheongang, standing right in front of me, was one of them.

He raised two wrinkled fingers.

"Second, money."

"Why do you need money?"

"Because you need elixirs for the recipient to absorb. The practitioner must guide and circulate the qi filling the recipient's body. Every sect has its own method, but it is no exaggeration to say the process costs a thousand gold."

“It would be difficult for anyone outside the Nine Sects and One Gang[1050] or the Five Great Families.[1051]”

“Not merely difficult. Extremely difficult. Was it Baek Museong? That Huashan-something fellow seems to have undergone it.”

This was an investment in the most literal sense. Sects selected promising young talents with bright futures and performed the procedure on them.

If Baek Museong was a blue-chip stock, Huashan would certainly have considered him worth the investment.

“Then what about Cheongpung?”

“Do you think the Sword Saint would have simply stood by and watched? He must have refined the boy’s body bit by bit from a very young age.”

Damn it. I’m the only one who missed out.

I had thought the Jin Family of Taiyuan was at least a silver spoon by Murim standards. But compared to the diamond-spoon babies who underwent the procedure as casually as double-eyelid surgery,[1052] we were nothing.

“What’s the third and final requirement?”

“Endurance.”

“Huh?”

“Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow changes the bones, muscles, and constitution one was born with. The bones and muscles twist and settle back into place, and the process inevitably causes tremendous pain.”

“How painful are we talking?”

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation.

“Painful enough to kill you.”

“…Painful enough to kill me?”

“People really do die.”

“Gasp.”

“In the Sichuan Tang Clan, they fill a jar with more than a thousand different venomous creatures, and then…”

The longer Jeok Cheongang talked, the more my stomach seemed to shrivel. I swallowed hard.

“T-That’s only how the Sichuan Tang Clan does it, right?”

“Of course. Our sect has its own secret method.”

“You don’t stack up more than a thousand logs, make me climb on top, and set them on fire or something…?”

[1050] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a traditional grouping of major martial-arts organizations in Murim fiction.

[1051] The Five Great Families are a grouping of prominent martial-arts families in Murim fiction.

[1052] Double-eyelid surgery creates or accentuates a crease in the upper eyelid. It is a familiar cosmetic procedure in South Korea.

"…"

"I guess not. Sorry."

"What the hell do you think our sect is?"

Jeok Cheongang glared at me with round, bulging eyes before shaking his head.

"Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow cannot be prepared overnight. Today, this old man will merely straighten your bones and muscles with internal energy. Whether you stuff yourself with elixirs afterward is your concern."

"Ah. Okay."

Come to think of it, Jeok Cheongang had arrived empty-handed. If he had intended to perform the procedure properly, he would have brought elixirs and all the other necessities.

"Should I take off my clothes, then?"

"Ask me that one more time, and I'll strip off your skin as well."

I stripped off every piece of clothing I was wearing at the speed of light.

Jeok Cheongang's gaze roamed over my completely naked body, and a strange look entered his eyes.

"This is…"

"Yes?"

"Ah, never mind. It's nothing."

What was that? Why did the atmosphere suddenly become so ominous?

As I wondered what was wrong with the old man, I realized something and grinned.

"Come on, now. We're all friends here. Why are you acting like that?"

"…?"

"Honestly, this size is absolutely not normal. I was shocked myself when I first saw it. Do you know the Amazon? There's something called a black anaconda there. It's just—whoosh. Really enormous. Whew."

"…!"

"I understand that you're surprised, but you still can't touch it. Got it?"

Whoosh—whack!

With a short rush of wind, a tightly clenched fist slammed into my temple.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Status effect: Unconsciousness has been removed.

I came to with the System notification, stared up at the familiar ceiling, and muttered, “Damn, you could’ve just said you wouldn’t touch it. Why hit me?”

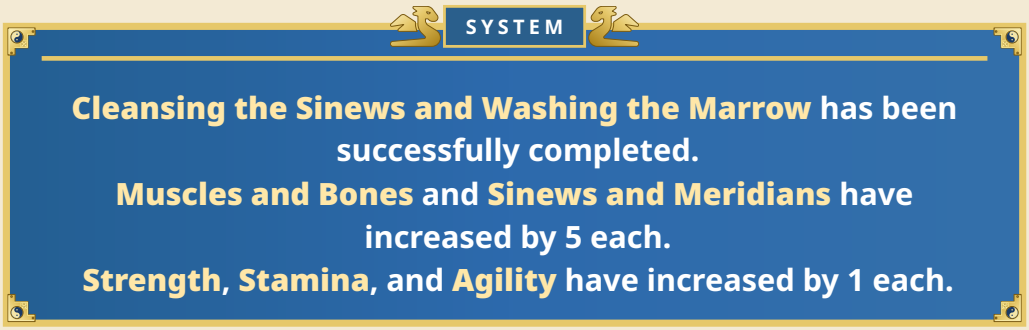
Did he really want to touch it that badly? Was he upset because I turned him down so firmly?

I rubbed my throbbing temple and sat up. Several System messages I had not yet read were floating before my eyes.

“Huh? The cleansing is already over?”

I looked around, but Jeok Cheongang was nowhere to be seen.

Apparently, he had finished the procedure in a flash and left while I was unconscious. At least, that was what the messages suggested.



“Oh…”

A weak murmur of admiration escaped me.

It was definitely good. I was undoubtedly better off than before. This was the sort of improvement that would normally require one level-up and plenty of steady training.

But…

“Is that really all?”

Form is temporary, but class is forever.

It might have been a makeshift procedure performed without proper preparation, but cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow was still cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow.

I had expected some incredible effect. Instead, I was so disappointed that I was practically bewildered.

“What the hell?”

In Murim novels, these things were practically cheat codes.

Bone Transformation and cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow were practically basic requirements for any protagonist.

Even a sickly weakling could undergo both, turn into a thug, and run rampant through the Murim.

So what was wrong with me?

“Did he just half-ass it?”

Just then, the door opened, and Hyuk Mujin cautiously poked his head inside.

"May I come in—gasp."

As I pulled on the clothes scattered across the floor, I said:

"Just so we're clear, if you get any strange ideas, I'll crack your skull. And by skull, I mean your head."

"Then why are you naked?"

"The old man worked on my body."

"Your body? With you completely naked?"

"…You're making that sound weird."

Hyuk Mujin flinched and hurriedly waved his hands.

"N-No. That's not what I meant. Great Hero Jeok looked so strange when I ran into him earlier that I came to see if something had happened."

"His expression was strange?"

"His face was completely rigid. He looked like he'd been startled by something, or maybe like he was angry."

"Really?"

"Yes. He looked so frightening that I couldn't even bring myself to speak to him."

"Why?"

"How would I know?"

I tilted my head. Had something happened all of a sudden?

Jeok Cheongang walked along, lost in thought.

People who recognized him bowed from every direction, but his mind was filled with only one person.

Jin Taekyung.

His assessment of the young man had changed several times over the past few days.

First, he had been an interesting fellow. Then he had become an infuriating bastard who burned his sect's martial arts manual. And today, the moment Jeok Cheongang saw Jin Taekyung's naked body for the first time, a new thought had occurred to him.

What a strange fellow.

Even at a glance, Jin Taekyung possessed exceptional bones and muscles. They were so remarkable that it seemed a waste for him to languish in a backwater like this.

But once Jeok Cheongang saw the body hidden beneath his clothes with his own eyes, he realized it was beyond anything he had expected.

How can a body be this perfectly balanced?

The human body grew over time, but balance was another matter.

One's everyday posture and even the smallest habits in how one dressed, ate, and lived could throw that balance off.

A swordsman who wielded his sword with his right hand would naturally have more muscle and greater strength in his right arm.

It was as natural as water flowing downhill.

But Jin Taekyung was different.

…What is this fellow?

The length and angle of every bone. The shape and form of every muscle.

Every part of him was in perfect balance.

It was as though some unknown, omnipotent being had drawn one half of Jin Taekyung on a blank sheet of paper, folded it over, and then opened it again.

Could he have undergone cleansing steadily since childhood? No. Even cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow couldn't achieve this.

In the past, Jeok Cheongang had agonized and conducted extensive research for Jangcheon, whose bones and muscles were lacking. Eventually, he had found the best possible method and performed the procedure on him.

The treatment had succeeded, but that experience had taught Jeok Cheongang one thing.

Even cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow has its limits.

The phrase *perfect balance* did not belong anywhere near the human body.

Even if one spent ten thousand gold instead of a thousand, minute flaws would remain. But Jin Taekyung was different.

Jeok Cheongang had kneaded and touched his unconscious body from head to toe.

He had felt the tough, elastic skin and the strength filling both the surface and the depths of his body. He had circulated his internal energy through Taekyung's body and confirmed the broad, sturdy Sinews and Meridians within.

And then he had been stunned.

How can a body like this exist?

It was perfect. He almost wondered if this was what the legendary Bone Transformation he had only heard about would look like.

Jeok Cheongang had met several Supreme Peak masters in his life, including the peerless master Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint.

But he could say this without hesitation: Of all the bones and muscles he had ever seen, Jin Taekyung's were the finest under heaven.

Could it be…

Jeok Cheongang had been staring blankly for some time when a thought flashed through his mind, making his entire body tremble.

The Murim held sayings passed down like legends from the distant past.

The Heavenly Martial Physique, said to be born through a caprice of Heaven once every several hundred—or perhaps even a thousand—years, was one of them.

The Heavenly Martial Physique? I must be out of my mind.

But the longer Jeok Cheongang examined Jin Taekyung's body, the deeper his suspicions grew and the more tangled his thoughts became.

It would not have been an exaggeration to say that there was nothing about that body in need of correction.

Once he finished the mere formality that could barely be called cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow, his concerns only deepened.

If that boy truly possesses the Heavenly Martial Physique, what would happen if he learned martial arts even greater than those he knows now and absorbed elixirs?

His thoughts continued chasing one another long after he left the pavilion.

At last, the desire coiled deep within Jeok Cheongang's heart raised its head.

"What if… I taught that boy?"

The mutter escaped him before he realized it, and Jeok Cheongang was startled.

A Disciple?

His only Disciple had betrayed their sect and was no longer of this world.

The wound from that betrayal had not even healed, and he was already thinking of taking another Disciple.

Worse, he was over a hundred years old, and the infirmities of old age had already begun to cloud his mind.

Even if I don't do it, Mae Jonghak could find a worthy talent and carry on our sect's legacy.

He had told no one, but Jeok Cheongang had planned to seek out the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak as soon as he left the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Mae Jonghak possessed martial arts counted among the strongest under heaven and had no selfish ambitions. Jeok Cheongang planned to entrust the Fire Gate Clan's succession to him.

And now, at this late hour, I entertain such an absurd thought? Jeok Cheongang, you stupid bastard. You fool.

Jeok Cheongang was sighing heavily and staring up at the sky when a voice reached him.

"Great Hero Jeok. Is something troubling you?"

The polite voice belonged to Jin Wikyung, a giant of a man.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been thinking of Jin Taekyung at that very moment, flinched.

"Uh, yes?"

It was already the third day since Jeok Cheongang had begun staying at the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Seeing him act so unlike himself, Jin Wikyung asked cautiously, “Is there perhaps something making you uncomfortable…?”

“N-No. It’s nothing.”

“Then I’m relieved.”

Jeok Cheongang waved a hand while gazing toward a distant mountain.

“There’s nothing wrong with this old man. I’m perfectly fine, so go about your business.”

“Um, did you perhaps have something you wished to say to me?”

“I said I don’t.”

“Are you certain?”

“I said I am! Stop worrying about it and be on your way.”

“…Great Hero Jeok?”

“Ah, what is it?”

When Jeok Cheongang finally exploded, Jin Wikyung hesitated before speaking.

“Great Hero Jeok, you are standing directly in front of my office.”

“…”

“Would you care to come in for a cup of tea and a conversation?”

After a brief silence, Jeok Cheongang cleared his throat.

“Ahem. Give me liquor instead of tea.”

Whatever his mind might have said, Jeok Cheongang’s feet had been honest.

Chapter 198

An awkward atmosphere hung inside the office.

Jin Wikyung and Jeok Cheongang stole glances at each other as they sipped their tea and liquor.

Great Hero Jeok came here in person. What could this be about?

Has he been possessed by a ghost? Of all places, why did he have to come here?

But even silence had its limits.

After draining several cups in quick succession, Jeok Cheongang finally spoke. Since he was already here, he might as well clear up his questions about Jin Taekyung before leaving.

“I just came from seeing that fellow.”

“Ah, you mean Taekyung.”

Jin Wikyung immediately understood and carefully gauged his mood.

He had already heard the whole story. Jeok Cheongang had helped the Jin Family of Taiyuan because of the emotional debt he carried toward his dead Disciple.

But he was worried that the anger caused by the martial arts manual incident two days ago might not have faded yet.

“Is this perhaps about the martial arts manual?”

“This old man has already erased that from his memory. No matter how precious a manual may be, people are more important. Don’t you agree?”

“…”

“What? What’s with that expression?”

“Oh, it’s nothing.”

After beating him into a pulp, he’s talking about how people are more important now?

Jin Wikyung swallowed the words hovering at the tip of his tongue.

“In any case, I thought I might have hit him a little too hard, so I went to treat his body by cleansing his sinews and washing his marrow.”

“C-Cleansing his sinews and washing his marrow? You mean the cleansing I know of?”

Jeok Cheongang nodded at Jin Wikyung’s wide-eyed stare.

“Is there another kind?”

“N-No. I was simply too surprised.”

“Surprised?”

“How could I not be? Someone as extraordinary as Great Hero Jeok performed cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow on my younger brother. This is a tremendous blessing for our family.”

As Jeok Cheongang gazed at Jin Wikyung's delighted face, he realized something.

"I see. I suppose you might not have known."

"Pardon?"

You can only see as much as you know. Even Jeok Cheongang, one of the most renowned Supreme Peak masters in the world, had never imagined that Jin Taekyung's bones and muscles could be that exceptional.

How, then, could Jin Wikyung have known?

Perhaps it was fortunate that I found out now.

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue softly before speaking.

"The effect of cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow was minimal."

"What do you mean? How could cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow have no effect?"

"That isn't what I mean. It would be more accurate to say that Jin Taekyung doesn't need it. It's too early to make a definite judgment, but…"

Jeok Cheongang added in a low voice:

"I suspect he may possess the Heavenly Martial Physique."

"!"

For a brief moment, shock flashed across Jin Wikyung's face.

But a moment later, he nodded calmly, prompting Jeok Cheongang to ask, "Did you already know?"

"I didn't. Things simply make sense now."

"Understand what?"

"Taekyung's astonishingly rapid progress in martial arts. If he possesses the Heavenly Martial Physique—if it truly is that Heavenly Martial Physique—then everything can be explained."

"Astonishingly rapid?"

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his brow and continued.

"That fellow has certainly accomplished a great deal for someone his age, but not enough to call it astonishing. If anything, compared to the legends of the Heavenly Martial Physique, his progress seems lacking."

His voice rang with certainty.

And for good reason. In his youth, Jeok Cheongang had been every bit as accomplished as Jin Taekyung—more so, if anything.

The Supreme Peak masters who now dominated the Murim had displayed their genius from childhood. Compared to them, Jin Taekyung's current realm was nothing out of the ordinary.

"The Heavenly Martial Physique is exactly what its name implies: bones and muscles bestowed by Heaven. Once every several hundred years—perhaps even

once every thousand—a whim of Heaven causes a god to dwell within the body of a mere human. But the boy is only…”

“At the beginning of the Peak realm.”

“Exactly. The world is vast, and talented people are everywhere. Cheongpung alone is proof of that.”

Everything Jeok Cheongang said was true.

The people sheltered by the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were not the only ones who existed.

There were undoubtedly young talents whose names had not yet reached the Central Plains, as well as people who had buried themselves in the countryside while training in martial arts.

If someone scoured every corner of the world, they would likely uncover several Supreme Peak masters approaching the level of the One God, the Three Saints, and the Ten Kings.

“That is why this old man cannot be certain. The boy is undoubtedly exceptional, but… this is not enough. Perhaps the legend is only a legend. Or perhaps his martial talent is inferior to his physique.”

“How interesting.”

“What is?”

“I thought the exact opposite.”

Jin Wikyung smiled faintly at Jeok Cheongang’s questioning expression.

“My younger brother’s martial talent is the greatest under heaven. No, it would not be an exaggeration to call it the greatest in all history.”

“W-What did you say?”

Jeok Cheongang barely managed to suppress the curse rising in his throat.

Even he, a living legend in all but name, did not dare claim to be the greatest beneath Heaven. And this man was calling his younger brother the greatest in all history?

Still, the confidence and conviction in Jin Wikyung’s voice compelled Jeok Cheongang to ask, “What makes you think that?”

Jin Wikyung silently held up three fingers.

“Three months.”

“…”

“That is how long Taekyung has been learning martial arts.”

“!”

“It’s also how long it took a Third Rate wastrel who frequented pleasure houses to become a Peak master.”

For an instant, Jeok Cheongang’s vision went white. Lightning flashed through his mind, and his heart pounded violently.

Three months to rise from Third Rate to Peak.

Absurd.

Utterly impossible.

But…

It is possible. If he possesses the Heavenly Martial Physique.

Jeok Cheongang was a Supreme Peak master.

Yet even he—powerful enough to kill a thousand people alone—was merely an old man whose body was withering beneath the force of time.

The Heavenly Martial Physique, however, was a being born of Heaven's choice and whim.

How could a mere human presume to guess Heaven's intentions?

Is this what lies beyond Heaven?

Jeok Cheongang slowly rose and approached the window. When he pushed open the tightly shut panes, an endless blue sky stretched before him.

As the cold wind rushed inside, he suddenly wondered:

Why had Heaven chosen Jin Taekyung?

And why had it brought the two of them together?

Who are you? Is there really someone there?

No answer came.

Jeok Cheongang stared in silence at the wisps of cloud drifting through the clear, tranquil sky. After a long while, he finally spoke.

"I think we need more liquor. What do you say?"

Jin Wikyung answered with a smile.

"Excellent. I was getting tired of tea myself."

The next day, Hyuk Mujin came to me with unexpected news.

"They want you to attend the banquet."

"Me?"

"Who else would they mean?"

I answered without a moment's thought.

"I don't want to."

Sitting around taking up space would only make me restless.

People would gawk at me like I was a monkey in a zoo, and my biggest fan, Prince Shangshan, would probably ask for an autograph.

I would much rather hole up in my pavilion, circulate my qi, and think about martial arts. That sounded a hundred times better.

"Just tell them I can't go."

“It was the Lesser Family Head’s order.”

“Even better. My brother won’t make a fuss, will he? Besides, wouldn’t people find it strange if my closed-door training ended after only three days?”

“Just tell them you gained some insight. If you say that’s what happened, who’s going to argue?”

“…”

He had a point.

I narrowed my eyes at Hyuk Mujin, who seemed to be getting more logical by the day.

“I’m still a patient.”

“You’ve already recovered. When I saw you this morning, nearly all your bruises were gone.”

Just as Hyuk Mujin said, most of the bruises that had covered my upper body had already disappeared.

Judging by that, cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow really had done something.

Of course, gaining more stats would have been far more useful from my perspective.

Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head as though this was giving him a headache.

“Why don’t you just go?”

“Tell them I’m still in pain. Who’s going to argue when I’m the one saying it hurts?”

“Great Hero Jeok.”

“Huh?”

“He said you should have recovered by now, so don’t even think about pulling anything. Otherwise, he’ll come here and drag you out himself.”

“Damn it. That old man is still at the banquet hall?”

“He drank with the Lesser Family Head all night, then showed up a moment ago completely wasted.”

I let out a deep sigh.

Jeok Cheongang had said he would remain at the Jin Family of Taiyuan only until this gathering ended.

According to the original schedule, he should have left yesterday. But more and more people had arrived, including several heavyweights, and the gathering had been extended. Naturally, so had his stay.

“Shit. Fine, let’s go. Let’s go.”

“Good choice. If you refused, I was going to be the one who died.”

I followed Hyuk Mujin, who was grinning foolishly, toward the banquet hall.

It was still crowded enough to make a marketplace look deserted, but perhaps because they had finally begun controlling admission, there were far fewer people than on the first day.

“We had no choice. More people kept coming every day. With that many eating and drinking from morning to night, the expense was one thing, but we simply ran out of room.”

“You should’ve turned more of them away. It still looks packed.”

“If we turn away any more, people will curse us. Everyone left is at least the head of a small martial arts academy.”

“So you’re preserving their pride?”

“Something like that. We even gave each person a gift when we sent away the people who had been here on the first day.”

They’re even managing grassroots opinion?

Whether it was all part of some careful calculation or simply an act of genuine kindness, Jin Wikyung was undeniably capable.

He was different from the other martial artists who put their pride and martial arts first. Could he be what you would call a bureaucrat-style martial artist?

Without such an excellent CEO at its head, the Jin Family of Taiyuan probably could never have risen to its current position.

“Hey, our youngest! My beloved little brother, you’ve come!”

“…”

Yes, he would have been perfect if not for things like this.

His face was bright red from all the liquor he had drunk. As Jin Wikyung bellowed from the seat of honor, laughter erupted throughout the hall.

He really went all out. He really did.

Jin Wikyung was a Peak master. He could have purged the alcohol with his internal energy, so the fact that he was this drunk meant he had never intended to sober himself up.

Jeok Cheongang, seated beside him, was in much the same state.

“I summoned you ages ago. Why are you only showing up now?”

“…I came right away.”

“Right away, my ass. You dragged your feet saying you wouldn’t come, then hurried over the moment you heard this old man was here.”

“…”

“No matter how far you run, you’re still in the palm of my hand. Stop spouting nonsense and sit down.”

The old man really was frighteningly perceptive.

I exchanged nods with the familiar faces in the hall, including Baek Museong and Lee Seowol, then cautiously made my way forward.

The instant I sat down beside Jeok Cheongang, a liquor cup the size of a rice bowl appeared in front of me.

“Drink.”

“Oh. Yes.”

I filled the bowl to the brim and drained it in one go. As I wiped my mouth with my sleeve, Jeok Cheongang thrust the liquor bottle toward me again.

“One more.”

“Yes.”

I drained another bowl.

“More.”

“…Again?”

“What did you say?”

“No. The liquor just tastes so good, that’s all.”

Something about this feels ominous.

In the end, I emptied an entire jar by myself in less than fifteen minutes. Only then did the corners of Jeok Cheongang’s mouth curl upward in satisfaction.

“That’s more like it. You need to drink at least this much.”

“…”

Why did this remind me of a story I had once seen online about a university freshman welcome party?

The difference was that the person forcing me to drink wasn’t some senior from a fossilized class year.[1053]

It was the Fire King.

This is brutal right from the start.

Still, I had cleared the first hurdle.

I was taking a moment to catch my breath while the thoroughly drunk Jeok Cheongang went to relieve himself when someone suddenly spoke to me.

“May I pour you a drink?”

The speaker was a solidly built, middle-aged man.

He had stern eyes and tightly pressed lips. He looked at me with an unreadable expression before continuing:

“I am Ak Bulgun of the Shandong Yue Family.”

The Shandong Yue Family?

I had heard the name several times, both in novels and since arriving in the Murim.

I bowed awkwardly.

[1053] In Korean university slang, a “fossil” is a student from a much older entering class who is still around campus.

“Ah, I’m—”

“I already know. Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. Though when I heard about you from the cadets last year, you didn’t have that nickname yet.”

“…Cadets?”

What was this man talking about?

Ak Bulgun smiled faintly at my bewilderment.

“Have you heard of Heaven’s Gate Temple? I serve as a spear Instructor there.”

“Oh.”

“I don’t know whether you’re aware, but your second brother is rather famous at the academy. Naturally, stories about you found their way there as well.”

I let out a quiet laugh.

Until three months ago, I had been called the disgrace of my family. I didn’t need to hear the stories to know exactly what they had been.

“I doubt they were very flattering.”

“Rumors in the martial world are not to be trusted. You yourself are proof of that.”

“Who knows?”

I answered vaguely and drank the liquor he poured for me.

“But what brings you here?”

“I came to attend to some business, but then I received word from the academy. One of our cadets said he was visiting his family for a short while, only to stop responding entirely. They ordered me to bring him back.”

“Jin Mukyung—I mean, my second brother.”

“That’s right. I hear he is undergoing closed-door training?”

When I nodded, Ak Bulgun stroked his beard.

“That’s troublesome. He’ll have to leave within seven days at the latest, no matter what. Did he give you any indication before entering seclusion?”

“No. He’s the sort who won’t stop until he’s satisfied.”

“I know. I have taught him myself.”

He sighed softly, then abruptly asked, “What about you?”

“Me?”

“Why not become a cadet at Heaven’s Gate Temple while you have the opportunity? Ah, if the rumor that you are studying under the Fire King is true, then pretend you never heard me.”

Heaven’s Gate Temple, out of nowhere.

I hadn’t expected that.

Heaven’s Gate Temple was practically a gateway to success, filled with talented people from across the world whose abilities had already been recognized, exceptional instructors, and countless opportunities.

I had heard that if a cadet met certain conditions, they could even learn advanced martial arts, as Jin Mukyung had.

If I stay at the Jin Family of Taiyuan, there's a limit to how far I can grow.

The incident with the Roaring Fury Swordsman had taught me that. No matter what I obtained, without the strength to protect it, I would only end up at someone else's mercy.

I needed a turning point if I wanted to become stronger, and Heaven's Gate Temple offered both safety and opportunity.

Unless I really am the Fire King's Disciple, this is the best option available to me right now.

When I did not answer immediately, Ak Bulgun continued.

"The admission period has already passed, but I can grant you special permission."

"Special permission?"

"You are an exceptional talent."

Ak Bulgun's rough palm came to rest on my shoulder.

"What do you say? Will you become a cadet at Heaven's Gate Temple? Someone like you would be welcomed with open arms by the higher-ups."

"I…"

Just as I opened my mouth, a voice cut through the air.

"Take your hand off."

"!"

A wave of scorching heat burst over us, carrying alcohol fumes so overpowering that my vision swam.

Yet there was not a trace of drunkenness in Jeok Cheongang's voice.

"I said take your hand off what's mine."

Chapter 199

"Take your hand off what's mine."

At Jeok Cheongang's words, the air grew heavy. A moment later, Ak Bulgun slowly removed his hand from my shoulder.

"Great Hero Jeok, I merely—"

A sharp voice cut him off.

"Who taught you to go around touching what belongs to someone else?"

Belongs to someone else?

Treating a person like an object was bad enough, but why was *I* the object in question? It wasn't as if I were Jeok Cheongang's Disciple or grandson.

I had been seriously considering Heaven's Gate Temple as a promising option. I hadn't expected him to come along and dump chili powder all over it.

What's gotten into this old man?

Unlike me, Ak Bulgun remained calm.

"I apologize for offending you, but I merely wished to offer Young Hero Jin an opportunity."

"An opportunity, my ass. You can dress it up however you like, but you're still trying to spirit him away behind my back. Did you think this old man wouldn't see through your filthy intentions?"

"Spirit him away? Certainly not."

"Then what?"

Even under Jeok Cheongang's fierce glare, Ak Bulgun continued without wavering.

"I came here not as a member of the Shandong Yue Family, but as an Instructor of Heaven's Gate Temple. In conveying the wishes of the academy's higher-ups, how could I allow personal feelings to influence me?"

"So those so-called higher-ups gave you those orders without even knowing what sort of relationship this boy and I have?"

"If I may be so bold, could I ask what exactly that relationship is?"

"What?"

Jeok Cheongang glared at Ak Bulgun, his face stiff.

"This old man entrusted that boy with our sect's divine artifact."

"I am well aware. I have heard all about it."

"Then you must know what that means. Are you mocking this old man?"

"How could I dare harbor such an intention? It is simply…"

Ak Bulgun looked back and forth between Jeok Cheongang and me.

"You do not appear to be master and Disciple at all, so I cautiously conveyed the offer."

"…"

"…"

We both flinched.

I didn't know how warm and affectionate the average master-Disciple relationship was supposed to be, but a Disciple probably didn't address his master as "Great Hero."

And Jeok Cheongang's treatment of me hadn't exactly suggested otherwise.

Damn, he's sharp.

We had been far too careless. When I glanced aside, I saw Jeok Cheongang chewing on his lip. Ak Bulgun's gaze deepened at our reaction.

"Young Hero Jin also hesitated when he heard the offer. Had he truly been your Disciple, he would have rejected it without a second thought."

Everything he said was true, so there was no way to argue.

Why would the Disciple of the Fire King—one of the handful of Supreme Peak masters beneath Heaven—ever enter Heaven's Gate Temple?

It would be like ignoring a lump of gold to pick up a pretty pebble.

Looks like the truth is coming out anyway.

The three of us weren't the only ones at the table of honor. Everyone else was looking away, but their ears were pricked.

Once word of today's conversation spread, my sturdy shield of being the Fire King's Disciple would vanish. And after that?

Every bastard under the sun will come crawling out.

Until recently, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been little more than a fleshless skeleton.

But things were different now. We had put on a fair amount of meat, and the wolves would soon start prowling around us.

They would watch one another until the time was right, then pounce.

The Fire King was already over a hundred years old. His death would be the starting signal for those bastards to sink their teeth into us.

And the Zhongnan Sect will obviously be first in line.

I had to grow stronger before then. To do that, Heaven's Gate Temple was a hundred times better than the empty title of the Fire King's Disciple, an illusion that would disappear before long.

All right. I'm going to Heaven's Gate Temple.

Having made up my mind, I turned to Ak Bulgun.

"Actually, I…"

I have no relationship with Great Hero Jeok. We just happen to share a slight connection. I desperately want to enter Heaven's Gate Temple, so would someone

like me qualify for a scholarship? Or perhaps the Shanxi Province rural special-admissions track?[1054]

All the words poised to pour out of me like a waterfall were dammed by a single sentence from Jeok Cheongang.

“He is my Disciple.”

“Great Hero Jeok and I have no relationship at all… Pardon?”

What the hell was he talking about?

I whipped around to stare at Jeok Cheongang.

What did he just say?

Ignoring my bewildered gaze, Jeok Cheongang continued as calmly as ever.

“I intended to keep him hidden until he was ready, but it seems that will no longer be possible. Everyone appears to have plenty to say on the matter, so I might as well settle it once and for all.”

“No, wait—”

The voice I had barely managed to force out was swallowed by Jeok Cheongang’s shout, charged with internal energy.

“I proclaim this to the Murim beneath Heaven!”

A terrifying wave of energy shook the ground and pressed down upon the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s estate. Every other sound vanished, and hundreds of pairs of eyes turned toward us.

It had happened before I even had a chance to stop it.

Veins bulged on Jeok Cheongang’s liver-spotted neck.

“I, Jeok Cheongang, eighteenth Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan, hereby accept Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan as my Disciple and name him heir to our sect’s orthodox lineage!”

A brief silence followed. Then those who understood his words erupted into thunderous exclamations and cheers.

It was the moment when everyone’s lingering suspicions became fact—and one old man’s perfect bullshit became reality.

And I…

“I have committed a grave discourtesy. I apologize to you as well, Young Hero Jin. I will convey the news properly to Heaven’s Gate Temple. No one would dare interfere with Great Hero Jeok’s Disciple, so even the Temple Master will surely abandon the idea.”

Every path into Heaven’s Gate Temple—or to becoming anyone else’s Disciple—had just been slammed shut.

Ak Bulgun chuckled at my devastated expression.

“Look at you. Why the long face on such a joyous day?”

[1054] This refers to a Korean special-admissions category for applicants from rural areas.

"…"

Because I knew perfectly well that there wasn't even a one-percent chance Jeok Cheongang would actually take me as his Disciple.

I had gained absolutely nothing, yet my entire future had been blocked off. My clenched fists trembled.

Damn old man.

I could already see my bleak future unfolding before me. He wouldn't teach me a single martial art, but he would torment me, beat me up, and send me on every petty errand imaginable.

At best, I would become an Inventory for storing his belongings.

I'm screwed.

Congratulations poured in from all around the table of honor, but I didn't hear a word of them.

Jeok Cheongang spread his arms wide, wearing a thoroughly fake smile.

"Come. Let your master give you a hug, my dear Dis. ci. ple."

"…"

"Oh, look at this rascal. Shy because everyone's watching, are you? Ho ho ho."

Laughing heartily, Jeok Cheongang secretly crooked a finger.

At that moment, an irresistible force unlike anything I had ever felt seized my ankle.

One step. Two steps.

My feet began moving toward him against my will.

…Seizing an Object Through Empty Space?

Was this really happening?

The tiny old man finally pulled me into a tight embrace and moved his lips.

"Hey. Smile."

"…Yes."

"Put your arm around my shoulders. Get those corners of your mouth up to your ears."

Fuck it. Whatever happens, happens.

With our arms around each other's shoulders, we beamed like a loving master and Disciple. Instead of camera flashes, thunderous cheers rained down around us.

And that day, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao received a hyper-rare, limited-edition autograph:

Fire King & Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

Late that night, darkness lay thick over the estate.

Standing behind a secluded wall on the Jin Family of Taiyuan's grounds, I finally spoke.

"Why are you doing this to me?"

The small silhouette gave no answer.

"Protecting the Jin Family of Taiyuan? Fine. I'm grateful for that. I'm grateful that you drove those Zhongnan bastards away, too. But!"

"…"

"You're blocking my future! This has gotten so out of hand that I can't enter Heaven's Gate Temple anymore, and I can't take anyone else as my master either! Do you know why?"

Jeok Cheongang, who had been silently drinking straight from a liquor bottle, answered.

"Because no matter how foolhardy someone might be, they would never approach this old man's Disciple."

"Yes, exactly! Great Hero Jeok, you've completely blocked every path ahead of me!"

"I see."

"That's not the point! You're more than smart enough to know better, so why are you doing this? I have to make a living, too!"

Glug. Glug. Buuurp.

Jeok Cheongang drained the bottle to the last drop, let out a tremendous belch, and stared at me.

"You know better yourself, so why are *you* acting this way?"

"Pardon?"

The liquor bottle in his hand suddenly struck the wall.

Whoosh—BOOM!

Ordinarily, the bottle should have shattered with a sharp crash.

Instead, the wall exploded with a deafening roar.

The round liquor bottle was already rippling with tangible internal energy.

"Have you forgotten who this old man is? Why, you little—are you trying to die?"

"Gasp!"

"Even a full prostration wouldn't be enough, and you dare raise your voice? You wet-behind-the-ears little bastard, I ought to…"

"W-Wait! Calm down! Please calm down!"

"Calm down? Would you like to lie nice and still in a grave until your bones turn to dust?"

"…"

I had briefly forgotten.

The old man in front of me might have looked like the head honcho at a nursing home, but he was a notorious thug in the Murim.

Then I remembered that what he extorted from people wasn't money, but their lives. The blood in my veins seemed to turn cold.

I hit the wrong nerve.

The night was already dark, but now my vision went black as well.

Then Jeok Cheongang, who had been staring at me, abruptly spoke.

"Do you hate it that much?"

"Pardon?"

"Is taking this old man as your master truly so unbearable?"

"…"

What the hell was he talking about when he had no intention of making me his Disciple?

I had plenty to say, but keeping my mouth shut was clearly the better way to extend my lifespan.

Unfortunately, Jeok Cheongang had no intention of letting me stand there in silence, avoiding his gaze.

"Tell me."

"W-What?"

"Judging by your expression, you have plenty on your mind. Tell me what you're thinking."

"I don't have anything like that."

"You don't?"

BOOM!

What remained of the wall crumbled into dust and scattered.

I stared blankly at it, then hurriedly opened my mouth.

"Now that I think about it, I do."

"You just said you didn't."

"I didn't, but it turns out I did."

"Fine. Tell me."

I had blurted it out in a panic, but now that I actually had to speak, my heart shriveled. I fidgeted with my fingers and cleared my throat.

"Well, the thing is, it's a little…"

"Speak frankly. I want your honest answer, without a single lie."

"Really?"

"No matter what you say, I won't touch a hair on your head. I swear it by the gods of Heaven and Earth."

"You don't believe in the gods of Heaven and Earth."

"…"

"…"

I must have hit the nail on the head.

Jeok Cheongang glared at me with a terrifying expression before finally forcing the words out.

"I started believing today. I don't know what damned bastard is up there in the heavens, but I saw something with my own eyes, so now I have no choice."

"…?"

I had no idea what he had seen, but he sounded sincere.

Only after making him stake the honor of his sect and his own name as well did I cautiously begin.

"First of all, your personality is a little…"

"A little?"

"Nasty, isn't it?"

"…"

"Actually, it's very nasty."

He looked incredulous, but the liquor bottle in his hand remained still. Emboldened, I continued.

"And you've got a nasty habit of hitting people."

"…"

"You remember what happened a few days ago, right? I know I was partly at fault, but does it make any sense to launch a Flame Divine Palm at me without warning?"

"…Go on."

"I'm not opposed to a reasonable amount of discipline, but that means a flick on the forehead or a few strokes with a switch. What kind of Disciple wants to train while getting hit with the Flame Divine Palm? That isn't the rod of love. It's the rod of death. The rod of death. One wrong hit and I'll die, I'm telling you."

Once I started, everything came pouring out as if a dam had burst.

Beginning with my first encounter with Jeok Cheongang, I aired every complaint I had accumulated since. The longer I went on, the stiffer his face became.

Still, this feels pretty damn good.

A quarter of an hour later, when my stormy confession finally ended, Jeok Cheongang asked in a subdued voice,

"Are you finished?"

"There's still one important thing left."

"That… phew."

Contrary to my expectations, the liquor bottle didn't come flying. Jeok Cheongang merely heaved several deep sighs.

"Say it."

"My biggest complaint is what I mentioned earlier. Why did you publicly declare me your Disciple when you aren't even going to teach me martial arts?"

"Is that the problem?"

"Of course it is! If I'm going to teach myself, entering Heaven's Gate Temple would be a hundred times better."

"Learning from this old man is a thousand times better than entering Heaven's Gate Temple."

"…"

Did he think I didn't know that?

I stared at him in disbelief. Then a thought suddenly flashed through my mind.

"Great Hero Jeok, could it be…?"

Jeok Cheongang replied curtly.

"What?"

"Never mind. I just had a ridiculous thought."

"Say it."

"No, there's no point. Let's just forget it."

"Say it if you don't want to die."

Oh. Then I had to say it. If I didn't want to die, I absolutely had to say it.

I gave a dry laugh.

"I wondered if perhaps you were actually thinking of taking me as a real Disciple, or something like that. It's nonsense, so you don't have to answer. Hahaha."

"…"

"Hahaha."

"…"

"Great Hero Jeok?"

Jeok Cheongang remained silent for a long while despite my calling him, then tossed out a single sentence.

"Would that be a problem?"

"What would?"

"I asked if there was something wrong with this old man being your master."

"…Pardon?"

What the hell was with this atmosphere?

Chapter 200

“I asked if there was something wrong with this old man being your master.”

“Pardon?”

What the hell was he talking about? Taken out of context, that line could put a romance-drama male lead to shame.

I covered my vital areas and slowly backed away.

“What?”

“N-Nothing. But what do you mean?”

“Forget it. Pretend you never heard me.”

Jeok Cheongang’s expression was an odd mix of inexplicable hope, irritation, and disappointment. He stared at me for a moment, then abruptly said, “You possess the Heavenly Martial Physique.”

“Heavenly Martial what?”

Jeok Cheongang frowned at my reaction.

“You don’t know about the Heavenly Martial Physique? Are you making fun of this old man?”

“I’ve never heard of it in my life.”

“…Heaven truly is heartless. How could it give such a thing to someone like you?”

He looked like he genuinely wanted to hit me.

Jeok Cheongang trembled as he clutched his liquor bottle, then let out a sigh.

“Then do you know anything about the Nine Yin Severed Meridians?”

“Oh, the Nine Yin Severed Meridians. I know about that.”

I had seen it plenty of times before. Did I have it right?

I rummaged through my old memories and pulled out a few keywords related to the Nine Yin Severed Meridians.

“An unusual constitution. Sickly. Smart. Dies young.”

“…”

“Am I wrong?”

“You have the gist of it. It is a type of severed-meridian condition in which powerful innate yin energy blocks the meridians and soon leads to death.”

“Then what about the Heavenly Martial Physique?”

Unease began creeping into my chest. The fact that he had brought up the Nine Yin Severed Meridians as an example only made it worse.

What if it lets me learn martial arts quickly, but there’s something wrong with my body that makes me die young? That would be a disaster.

Jeok Cheongang spoke with a solemn expression.

"The Heavenly Martial Physique is a martial constitution bestowed by Heaven, one that might appear only once every several hundred years."

A constitution bestowed by Heaven? It sounded incredible just hearing about it.

Which only made me more nervous. The Nine Yin Severed Meridians were practically a double-edged sword that traded genius-level intelligence for a short lifespan.

I stared tensely at Jeok Cheongang's mouth.

"And?"

"What do you mean, 'and'?"

"When am I going to die?"

"Why would you die?"

"I think I've been having headaches and feeling nauseous lately. My bones and joints ache even now."

Doctor Choi Tae—no, Jeok Cheongang—gave me a short and concise diagnosis.

"That's because this old man beat you."

"Oh."

"You didn't seriously think the Heavenly Martial Physique makes you die young like the Nine Yin Severed Meridians, did you?"

"Ahem."

"What kind of lunatic are you?"

Jeok Cheongang shook his head in disbelief.

"The Heavenly Martial Physique is as different from a severed-meridian condition like the Nine Yin Severed Meridians as Heaven is from Earth. Do you think it's called a gift from Heaven for no reason? You were blessed by heavenly fortune from the moment you were born with that body."

"Me?"

"I heard from the Lesser Family Head that you have only been seriously learning martial arts for three months. Do you truly believe your achievements so far were possible through effort alone?"

"Not really."

"You are where you are because you possess a constitution that allows you to make any martial art your own faster than anyone else."

Jeok Cheongang was only half right.

I didn't bother correcting him because what had supplemented my efforts wasn't an innate constitution. It was the System.

If I really possessed the Heavenly Martial Physique, I wouldn't have remained Third Rate until I turned twenty.

A promising tree showed its potential from the moment it sprouted.

If the real Jin Taekyung—the previous owner of this body—had been born with such heavenly fortune, he would surely have distinguished himself long ago.

This body doesn't possess the Heavenly Martial Physique.

I looked down at my hands. The size and length of my arms and hands, the shape of my muscles, and the strength hidden within them.

Everything was perfectly balanced, without the slightest deviation.

The System.

The points I gained from leveling up and training were converted into stats, and the System distributed those stats evenly.

Every tiny, delicate gear inside my body meshed perfectly with the rest.

Since it isn't innate, it isn't exactly the Heavenly Martial Physique… But at this point, could I call it an acquired Heavenly Martial Physique?

Jeok Cheongang had seen my body with his own eyes, so it wasn't strange that he had mistaken it for one.

And from my perspective, it was better to let him keep making that mistake.

It had taken only three months for a Third Rate wastrel who did nothing but drink to become a Peak master.

Without the Heavenly Martial Physique as an explanation, it wouldn't have been strange for people to suspect me of practicing demonic martial arts.

Either way, this worked out nicely.

The fact that even a Supreme Peak master like Jeok Cheongang could mistake my constitution for the Heavenly Martial Physique proved beyond doubt that my bones and muscles were exceptional.

And since I had none of the side effects associated with the Nine Yin Severed Meridians, this was an absolute win.

Is the road ahead finally lined with flowers?

When I thought about everything I had suffered until now, tears welled in my eyes.

I was lost in emotion when I sensed someone staring at me and turned my head.

Jeok Cheongang flinched when our eyes met, then abruptly looked up at the sky.

"T-The moon is bright."

I followed his gaze and mumbled:

"There are thick clouds covering it."

"…"

"Did you have something to say?"

"Ahem."

After repeatedly clearing his throat, Jeok Cheongang cautiously spoke.

"As you know, this old man owes you a debt."

"So?"

“I want to settle that debt properly before I leave this place. Is there anything you want from this old man?”

Honestly, nothing in particular came to mind.

If I had to name one thing, it would be for him to take back what he had said earlier.

But there was no chance Jeok Cheongang would do that. His pride wouldn’t allow it. I had to come up with a reasonable request that he could actually grant.

I scratched my head.

“Well, I haven’t really thought about it in detail, so I’m not sure.”

“Then think about it in detail.”

“Oh, I’ll tell you later if anything comes to mind. You’ll be staying for a few more days before you leave anyway.”

But Jeok Cheongang was firm.

“Right now.”

“Pardon?”

“I said tell me right now. There’s hardly anything to think about, is there?”

As he pressed me for an answer, Jeok Cheongang added in a mumble, “F-For example, perhaps you want to learn martial arts from this old man. Or you want to learn martial arts from this old man. Or you want to learn martial arts from this old man. Something like that.”

“…”

“It was only an example. Pay it no mind.”

“…”

“Ahem. Is there phlegm stuck in my throat? Ahem!”

I watched him for a moment before speaking.

“Great Hero Jeok. I’m only asking just in case.”

“Ahem! Ahem!”

“Do you want to take me as your Disciple?”

Jeok Cheongang froze in the middle of his violent coughing fit. His pupils shook as though caught in an earthquake.

“W-What are you talking about?”

“You heard me.”

“H-How absurd. You think this old man wants to take you as his Disciple?”

“…”

Yes. That’s exactly what it looks like.

At first, I had wondered if I was imagining things, but by this point, anyone who still didn’t get it would have to be a fucking idiot.

When I merely stared at him without saying anything, Jeok Cheongang was the one who grew flustered.

“You little bastard! What is that insolent look in your eyes?”

“I’m just looking at you. Don’t worry about it.”

“You seem to be laboring under a grave misconception, but you’re entirely wrong.”

“Right. Sure.”

“Do you think I would choose the heir to our sect, with its long and venerable history, so easily?”

“You chose one pretty easily earlier. And you said it in front of all those people, so you can’t take it back now.”

“Th-That… I can simply take another Disciple.”

“You said it was a single-successor, no-outside-transmission tradition, didn’t you? Either way, everyone in the world will think I’m the heir to the Fire Gate Clan.”

Struck right at the heart of the matter, Jeok Cheongang shrieked, “There isn’t a single reason for me to take you as my Disciple!”

“I possess the Heavenly Martial Physique.”

“Gasp.”

“It took me about three months to go from Third Rate to Peak. I wonder how long it’ll take me to reach Supreme Peak.”

“Y-You bastard. Do you think it’s that easy? Do you think Supreme Peak is some mutt’s name?”

“It was easy for me.”

“…”

How many times had I come within an inch of death?

It had been brutally difficult and painful, but from this point onward, it was going to be easy. No matter what.

While Jeok Cheongang struggled to find words, I muttered as though talking to myself.

“Actually, Supreme Peak might be difficult.”

“O-Of course it is.”

“Maybe by thirty?”

Jeok Cheongang’s mouth fell open.

“Th-Thirty? Supreme Peak?”

“Did I give myself too long? I deliberately padded it because it sounded difficult.”

I sighed and glanced sideways at him.

“Still, you must have been much faster than me, Great Hero Jeok. You’re powerful enough to rank among the Ten Kings, after all. And you had the Fire Gate Clan’s martial arts, too. Wow, I’m jealous. If I learned high-level martial arts like those, I’d become strong in no time.”

"!"

Jeok Cheongang stared at me with trembling eyes. I could easily imagine what was playing out in his head.

What would happen if the Heavenly Martial Physique met the Fire Gate Clan's supreme martial arts?

I had already displayed unbelievable achievements in only three months. It was possible that an unprecedented monster, unlike anything seen in history, would be born.

I'm almost there.

His pride kept him from saying the words aloud, so I drove in the final nail.

"Actually, this won't do. I'm thinking of visiting Huashan once this gathering ends."

"H-Huashan? Why would you go there?"

"Because of Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint. I hear the two of you are quite close. If I explain my circumstances properly, I might be able to become his Disciple without letting word get out…"

"No!"

The shout burst from him before he could stop it. Jeok Cheongang flinched and swallowed dryly.

"If you are perhaps considering it…"

"Pardon? I can't hear you. You're speaking too quietly."

"Whew."

Jeok Cheongang steadied his breathing and tried again.

"If you're interested, this old man could personally oversee your martial arts training."

I widened my eyes in feigned surprise.

"Are you serious?"

"Of course. A debt must be repaid, mustn't it?"

Perhaps he had belatedly decided that he needed to maintain his dignity. His voice was more stern than it had been until now.

It's already too late for that, old man.

Barely holding back a laugh, I replied, "What you've already done is more than enough."

"It is this old man's principle to repay a debt tenfold, even twentyfold."

"I see."

"Exactly."

"But aren't you leaving in a few days anyway? You seem very busy."

"It can be postponed. I plan to leave once you have achieved a certain level of progress."

"Ah, so you're the type who sees things through once you start."

“It is simply my nature.”

“What if I fail to reach the level you want, Great Hero Jeok?”

Jeok Cheongang deliberately hardened his expression.

“Now listen here, you little bastard! Why are you already assuming you’ll fail?”

“I’m sorry. I just don’t know how many years it might take.”

“Did you already forget what sort of person I said I was?”

“The kind who sees things through once you start?”

“Once a martial artist draws his sword, he should see it through—even if he has to cut down a mountain.”

“Wow, that’s impressive. As expected of you, Great Hero Jeok!”

I gave him a thumbs-up, then asked in a suggestive tone, “But at this point, doesn’t that make us master and Disciple?”

“!”

After a brief silence, Jeok Cheongang shook his head vigorously.

“Master and Disciple? What nonsense! I am merely repaying a debt.”

“Ah, I see. I misunderstood your intentions, Great Hero Jeok. Please accept my sincere apologies.”

“…Ahem.”

Jeok Cheongang coughed uncomfortably before continuing.

“But I think we need to change the way you address me.”

“The way I address you?”

“Although we are not, well, truly master and Disciple, people are watching. Shouldn’t we at least keep up appearances?”

“That’s true.”

The way I address him? What should I call him?

After a moment’s thought, one word slipped from my mouth.

“Then should I call you Master from now on?”

“…”

“Master?”

“H-Huh?”

Jeok Cheongang came to his senses as though he had just woken up and stared at me with a complicated, subtle gaze.

“Yes. That would be good.”

“Yes. Then when it’s just the two of us…”

“Old Master. Call me that.”

“Understood, Old Master.”

I bowed deeply to him.

The Supreme Peak master whose fame resounded throughout the world, Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

It was the moment my subtle relationship with him began.

After sending Jin Taekyung away, Jeok Cheongang leaned back against an old wall.

The voice he had just heard echoed endlessly through his mind.

Master.

It had been ten years.

Ten years since anyone had called him Master.

Jin Taekyung's build, face, and personality were all different, yet the sight of him reminded Jeok Cheongang of his dead Disciple.

As Jeok Cheongang quietly sank into thought, a faint smile suddenly appeared at the corner of his wrinkled mouth.

Not bad.

He had never imagined things would turn out this way, but he did not dislike it.

No, he even found himself looking forward to what lay ahead, filled with an inexplicable sense of cheer.

"Not bad. Not bad at all."

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh and looked up at the sky.

At some point, the dark clouds had parted, revealing a bright moon.

Chapter 201

"It's been hard to catch sight of you lately."

"Tell me about it. These days, I can't tell whether I'm a bodyguard or a chief steward."

Jin Wikyung laughed quietly at Wipeng's complaint.

"Bear with it for a few more days. More importantly, how did those matters we discussed turn out?"

"Everything is proceeding smoothly. The Sect Leaders we brought into the fold are obedient, and the local authorities and merchant world are actively cooperating."

If the Jin Family of Taiyuan was a ship sailing with a favorable wind, Jin Wikyung was its seasoned captain.

Starting with securing the loyalty of the smaller and mid-sized sects on the first day of the gathering, he had handled one major issue after another.

The Fire King kept the Murim side in line, while Prince Shangshan, a member of the imperial family, did the same with the authorities. As a result, there had been no trouble at all.

As for the merchant world, that went without saying.

Merchants were more sensitive to profit than anyone. Once they smelled money, it was only natural for them to come running.

After quickly organizing his thoughts, Jin Wikyung asked Wipeng, "What about the budget? How much do you think we'll have left?"

"We're short."

"What?"

The corners of Wipeng's mouth rose at Jin Wikyung's startled expression.

"I mean we're short on warehouses to store all the wealth."

"…Phew."

"Two warehouses were already full two days ago. Everything that has come in since then is being stored in empty pavilions."

Jin Wikyung released a sigh of relief and gave a quiet laugh.

"What a windfall."

"Great Hero Jeok's announcement yesterday was decisive. It finally convinced those who had remained uncertain until the very end."

"They're the real heavyweights."

"Indeed."

The wider a person's connections, the more likely they were to get pricked by thorns.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was clearly a goose laying golden eggs, but there were also powerful sects and great families—including the Zhongnan Sect—with which it had an uneasy relationship because of the Fire King.

"That must be why Seok Family Manor suddenly requested a private meeting after remaining quiet all this time."

Seok Family Manor was a giant that held tremendous sway over the merchant world.

The fact that they had finally stepped forward proved how certain they were of the Jin Family of Taiyuan's potential.

"Weighing their options is what they do best. Since they came late, they'll make up for it with a generous gift."

"They'd better. Show them in."

"Yes, my lord."

Not long after Wipeng left, a plump middle-aged man entered the office.

"Oh, my! Lesser Family Head! How long has it been?"

"It's been a long time, Chief Ha."

The middle-aged man was an Outer Steward of Seok Family Manor. Though he was only one of five, he wielded immense authority.

Jin Wikyung smiled gently at the man as he repeatedly wiped away his sweat.

"It's been three years since we last met. How is your Lord?"

"He's as hale and hearty as a young man in his prime. As it happens, he heard the wonderful news and wishes to meet you. As you know, Lesser Family Head, he wasn't feeling well the last time…"

"Yes, I remember. Quite clearly."

Jin Wikyung vividly remembered that day three years ago.

He had waited a full fifteen days before being granted a private audience, only to leave Seok Family Manor as though he had been chased out without ever seeing the Lord's face.

Finding the sedan chair of a high-ranking official outside Seok Family Manor's main gate had been a coincidence.

That was what he had chosen to believe.

That's how the Murim works.

But now their positions had changed.

The past three years had been short but eventful, and the arrogant Outer Steward who had once treated him like a beggar had somehow become a humble merchant.

So he does know how to speak politely. That's a first.

With a strange sense of amusement, Jin Wikyung listened attentively to Chief Ha.

He readily accepted Seok Family Manor's proposal to enter the Shanxi merchant world in earnest with the cooperation of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Naturally, the details would need to be reviewed, but Seok Family Manor's offer was extraordinarily generous.

"You've made a better offer than I expected. Generous enough to make me wonder whether this is really all right."

Chief Ha rubbed his hands together and laughed.

"I'm a merchant to the bone. I never conduct business at a loss."

There were different levels among merchants.

A Third Rate merchant exchanged goods. A Second Rate merchant purchased goods that could leave him a profit. A First Rate merchant bought the future.

Seok Family Manor was one of the greatest merchant houses in the world. They were aiming not for an immediate profit, but for returns dozens of times greater in the years to come.

You won't make that much off us. Our family will never dance to your tune.

In stark contrast to his thoughts, Jin Wikyung smiled broadly.

Life was not so easy that one could say whatever one wished and reveal every honest feeling. That was especially true when dealing with a cunning merchant.

"I'll arrange a place for you to stay. We can discuss the finer details then."

"Thank you, Lesser Family Head."

Chief Ha was about to rise from his seat when he stopped.

"Um…"

"Is there something else?"

"This is a difficult request, but might I be allowed to meet Great Hero Jeok?"

Being an Outer Steward of Seok Family Manor was a position of considerable authority, but the Fire King was an exception. Since arriving at the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Jeok Cheongang had not granted a private audience to a single honored guest.

Chief Ha continued wiping away his sweat.

"It has proved extraordinarily difficult. I tried visiting him myself, and I even sent a subordinate to discreetly request a meeting, but…"

"Oh, dear. Great Hero Jeok probably didn't take that well."

"Indeed. My man came back nearly crippled. That is why I have shamelessly come to ask you for this favor, Lesser Family Head."

Suppressing his laughter, Jin Wikyung replied, "I'm not sure. It might be possible after the gathering ends, but the next few days will be difficult."

"I noticed he hasn't been seen since yesterday. May I ask why?"

"He must be instructing my second younger brother."

"Ah, I see. My apologies for intruding."

Once Chief Ha had left the office, Jin Wikyung could no longer hold back his laughter.

The exhaustion weighing on his body and mind after several days of hosting the gathering seemed to lift all at once. In a cheerful voice, he called for his most trusted subordinate.

“Wipeng. Who’s next?”

It was early morning, before the sun had even risen.

The person who woke me was neither Hyuk Mujin nor Cheongpung.

Splash!

“Gah!”

The first thing I saw after opening my eyes to the cold-water ambush was Jeok Cheongang, glaring at me with his eyes wide open.

“W-What are you doing?”

“You slept like the dead until this hour. Are you out of your mind?”

“I only slept for two shichen.[1055] How is that sleeping like the dead?”

Jeok Cheongang launched into a lecture as I stared at him in disbelief.

“In four hours, you bastard, this old man could swing a weapon a thousand more times. And where did you learn the disrespect of not even paying your morning respects to your Master?”

“…Master?”

Jeok Cheongang flinched and stammered for a moment.

“W-We need to look that way to other people, don’t we?”

“…”

“To avoid suspicion, we need to act like a real master! Like a real Disciple! That’s the bare minimum!”

“Ah, yes.”

So the pioneer of method acting in the Murim was right here.

At my lukewarm response, Jeok Cheongang’s face turned bright red.

“Regardless, I won’t stand for you loafing around like this. Come with me. Now.”

“Where?”

“There’s a place this old man has picked out.”

I assumed he had found a secluded training ground, but Jeok Cheongang led me out of the Jin Family estate altogether and into a nearby mountain.

[1055] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[1056] One meter is approximately 3.28 ft.

Trees with trunks easily several meters[1056] around grew thickly in every direction, and the ground was firm.

"This will do."

Jeok Cheongang stopped in a wide clearing and set the pack slung across his back on a tree stump.

"What's that?"

"Never mind that. It's something we'll use later."

"Later?"

"Yes. Things that will make you writhe with pleasure."

"…"

Why was I suddenly thinking of whips, candlesticks, and masks?

As I cast an anxious sidelong glance at the pack, Jeok Cheongang spoke sternly.

"Stop sticking your nose where it doesn't belong and take out your spear."

"Ah, yes."

I'd had the good sense to bring several spears, and I planted them in the ground.

The reason Jeok Cheongang had come to find me so early was obvious.

Training.

Though he tried hard not to show it, Jeok Cheongang wanted to take me as his Disciple.

He kept stubbornly denying it because he still wasn't certain himself.

He's already made one painful mistake.

The wound Jopil had left in Jeok Cheongang's heart had not yet healed.

That was why he would surely keep watching and weighing whether he could accept someone like me as his Disciple before making his decision.

Even if he doesn't pass down the Fire Gate Clan's supreme martial arts right away, he'll still do his best to teach me.

This was guidance from a Supreme Peak master.

A single word of advice from someone who had gone farther down this path than I had was worth more than a thousand pieces of gold.

I lifted a well-balanced iron spear and swallowed.

"What do I do now?"

"Come at me."

"Pardon?"

"I said come at me. Use all your strength."

A smile spread across Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled lips.

"Thirty minutes. If you can make this old man retreat even one step, you win."

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest **One Step Back** has been created.
Quest
One Step Back
Fire King Jeok Cheongang wants to see your true ability.
Make him retreat within the time limit and prove your worth to him!
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: One Step Back (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

Make him retreat one step?

At first glance, it seemed easy, but there was a reason it was a Peak-Grade Quest.

Especially when the opponent was Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

I looked away from the Quest window and found Jeok Cheongang waiting with a relaxed expression.

“All right. Begin.”

Beep.

SYSTEM

29:59

The moment the time-limit window appeared in the air, I kicked off the ground and charged toward him.

Whoosh!

Whoosh!

The spearhead tore through the air. Compressed air burst outward, sending the old man’s white hair flying.

Jeok Cheongang dodged Jin Taekyung’s first thrust and thought,

What is this kid?

Fast.

And the spear carried enough force to shatter a boulder.

Even Jeok Cheongang, who had already examined Jin Taekyung’s body once, had not anticipated such speed and strength.

Whirl—whoosh! Boom!

Second strike, third, fourth…

He stabbed, slashed, and swept upward.

Every time Jeok Cheongang evaded the shower of spearheads pouring down like torrential rain, his astonishment grew like a snowball.

He's seasoned. As if he were born on a battlefield.

He was only twenty-one. Yet the trajectories and movements traced by his spearhead were no worse than those of any famous master in the martial world.

No. If anything, they were better.

Having encountered countless martial artists during the Great Faction War, Jeok Cheongang had learned one thing well.

A true martial artist is forged through countless real battles.

The Nine Sects and One Gang.

The Five Great Families.

They were unquestionably great powers that held sway over the world, but only a small number of their members had ever survived at the brink of death.

That was why the Demonic Cult, which had grown through conquest and the principle of Might Makes Right, had managed to swallow half the Central Plains.

How many disciples of prestigious great sects had died at the beginning of the war?

But this kid is different.

There was nothing hollow in his opening stance, and not a trace of hesitation.

The spearhead relentlessly seeking every vital point on his body and those cold, hardened eyes were badges worn only by those who had fought countless real battles and seen blood.

Shriek—whoosh!

The spinning spearhead vibrated.

Humm. Humm. Humm.

It sounded like hundreds of bees beating their wings, and the spearhead shooting toward him was sharper than a venomous stinger.

He's only been practicing martial arts for three months? This kid?

Judging by his movements alone, it looked more like three years.

No, thirty.

Jeok Cheongang knew nothing of the seven years Jin Taekyung had spent steeped in battle. He could only marvel.

…What an incredible kid.

Jeok Cheongang himself had spent his entire life obsessed with martial arts.

Yet even for someone who had achieved a great realm, what Jin Taekyung was displaying now was incomprehensible.

The greatest martial talent in history, was it?

Remembering Jin Wikyung's words, Jeok Cheongang's figure trembled with joy and awe.

Yes. You were right.

Overcome by the lingering emotion, he slowly closed his eyes.

Whoosh!

A streak of light shot toward his chest.

Jeok Cheongang's eyes snapped half-open. At the same time, his wrinkled hand seized the spearhead.

Crack!

His hands blazed with red flames, crushing and melting the spearhead.

Molten metal dripped onto the ground hardened by the cold wind.

"…Wow, shit. Isn't that cheating?"

Jin Taekyung muttered in disbelief.

Jeok Cheongang grinned at him.

"We're just getting started."

Chapter 202

Half an hour. A full thirty minutes.

Even if my opponent was the Fire King, I'd thought that if I put everything I had into it, I could make him retreat a little—just a little.

At least, I had until a moment ago.

How does that make any sense?

I backed away, appalled.

He had caught a spearhead spinning with internal energy in his bare hand. That made about as much sense as sticking your hand into a grinder.

But when that hand belonged to Fire King Jeok Cheongang, things were different.

Drip. Hiss.

Steam rose as molten metal struck the ground. Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue at the sight.

"Maybe it melted so quickly because it was scrap iron. You must have come into plenty of money this time, so tell them to use better iron."

"H-How did you do that?"

"You can do it too."

"Me?"

"Of course. Once you possess at least two jiazi's worth of internal energy[1057] and master our sect's martial arts to their utmost limits."

"…"

"Easy, right?"

As if.

When I stared at him in disbelief, Jeok Cheongang opened his mouth and let out a huge yawn.

"Taking it easy, aren't you? If I were you, I'd spend that time swinging my spear one more time."

"I was just about to."

I glanced at the time limit floating in the air and pulled out another spear.

Sixteen minutes remained. Nearly half the time had already passed.

I only need to make him retreat one step. Just one step…

But that was easier said than done.

I glared at Jeok Cheongang, who still stood leisurely in the same spot, and drew a deep breath.

"Huuup—"

Whoosh!

[1057] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; two jiazi are 120 years.

I kicked off the ground and charged. One long stride erased the distance between us, and I thrust out my spear.

Screeeech!

The corners of Jeok Cheongang's mouth rose as he watched me.

"I believe I said we were just getting started."

Boom!

He stamped his foot once.

The effect was terrifying.

The ground shook as though an earthquake had struck, and a flock of birds perched on the bare branches took flight.

In the slowed-down world, Jeok Cheongang's hand blurred for an instant and struck away dozens of stones floating in the air.

Straight toward me.

Shishishishik!

Dozens of stones, each propelled by internal energy. Every one of them was as deadly as a concealed weapon.

They must have carried even greater destructive power than the Head Elder's finger-flicking technique I had faced in the past.

But…

I've grown stronger too.

Humm. Humm. Humm.

My spear let out a deep hum.

I felt a unity with it on an entirely different level from when I had still been First Rate.

The Jin Family's Spear Technique, which had already reached Great Completion, and my footwork technique had merged into perfect harmony.

The insight I had gained from crossing the wall of the Peak realm flowed through them, revealing spear paths I could never have imagined before.

And then there were my increased stats.

I can do this.

Crack.

The spear shaft buckled beneath my crushing grip.

Then, in the next instant—

Whoooosh!

The power compressed like a spring exploded outward. Wind burst from the spearhead's arc as I swung it sideways with all my strength.

It was internal energy unleashed—and a storm of my own making.

Pssshhh.

Fine dust scattered in every direction, the last remnants of the stones caught in the spear's path.

"Well, look at you."

The obstacle was gone. Now it was time to hit him.

I charged at Jeok Cheongang, whose expression was equal parts disbelief and delight.

Whoosh! Shishishishik!

The spearhead, brimming with internal energy, tore through the air.

Jeok Cheongang dipped lightly at the waist to evade it. At the same time, heat surged from his right hand.

Whoom!

Blazing flames shot toward me—a mass of condensed Scorching Yang Qi.

I gritted my teeth and swung the spear shaft.

Clang! Krrrra-boom!

A deafening roar erupted, and tremendous force and heat engulfed my entire body. Jeok Cheongang burst into laughter at the sight of me standing there, charred black from head to toe.

"What kind of idiot tries to knock that away?"

"…Hah. I almost had it."

"Don't make me laugh. If this old man had used his full strength, you would have died just now."

I answered sullenly.

"I knocked it away because I thought I could."

"And that's why you look like that?"

"…I didn't know this would happen."

"I'll give you credit for staying on your feet—and for actually blocking it."

"But weren't you only supposed to defend?"

"Who told you that?"

Damn. Come to think of it, he hadn't.

I ripped off my half-charred shirt and tossed it aside.

"For someone bearing the mighty title of Fire King, aren't you using a little too much force against a kid young enough to be your grandson?"

"You're still wet behind the ears, yet you swing a spear at an old man old enough to be your great-grandfather? And you call yourself the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

"You're a Supreme Peak master, Old Master!"

"You possess the Heavenly Martial Physique."

"Do you seriously call that *mal*?"

"If it isn't *mal*—words—then is it a foal?"[1058]

"…"

"What? Why are you looking at me like that?"

Grind.

My hand tightened around the spear. I let out a hot breath.

"Hoo. Now I'm going to do this properly."

Jeok Cheongang dug inside his ear with his pinky.

"Hm? What was that? I can't hear a weakling who got turned into charcoal with one hit."

"…"

God, I hated this.

When he'd been tearing apart the Roaring Fury Swordsman, his banter had been the most satisfying thing in the world. Now that I was on the receiving end, it made my stomach turn.

"What are you going to do if I really make you retreat even one step?"

"It would be faster for the Heavenly Demon to become the Abbot of Shaolin."

"Grrk."

"You should only have enough time left to drink a glass of cold water. Do you think you can make this old man retreat before then? Not a chance."

Jeok Cheongang was telling the truth. Barely three minutes remained.

Judging by how our fight had gone so far, failing the Quest was practically a foregone conclusion.

But I still had one trump card I hadn't shown him.

I continued the conversation as naturally as I could.

"You're really going to regret saying that."

"What do I have to regret? I only wanted to see how skilled you were in the first place. Still, you show some promise, so if you continue to work hard…"

"That's a shame."

"Hm?"

I heaved a deliberate sigh at the puzzled Jeok Cheongang, pretending to be genuinely disappointed.

"If you didn't attack at all and only defended, I could succeed easily… But I suppose that wasn't one of the conditions."

"If this old man only defended, you could make me retreat?"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes flashed. Competitive pride, perhaps, or curiosity.

I couldn't tell exactly what emotion lay in his gaze, but one thing was certain: he had taken the bait halfway.

[1058] *Mal* means "words," but can also mean "horse," setting up Jeok Cheongang's reply about a foal.

I waved a hand as though I hadn't noticed.

"No. Forget you heard that. If I succeeded, wouldn't it damage your reputation?"

That sealed it.

"…Look at this brat."

Jeok Cheongang's cheek twitched, his expression difficult to describe. Finally, he nodded.

"I can see straight through your little scheme, but fine. Go ahead and try."

"You mean it?"

"Haven't you heard that the Fire King's word is worth a thousand pieces of gold? Once this old man says something, he always keeps his word."

"…Ah. Yes."

He'd even changed the first word and plagiarized the proverb.

Either way, I'd achieved what I wanted. I discarded the half-charred spear and pulled out my third one.

This one will probably be single-use too.

But if that was the price of completing a Peak-Grade Quest, it was absurdly cheap.

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes as I adjusted my stance.

"You aren't planning to use poison or some underhanded trick, are you?"

"Come on. Of course not."

I grinned and added,

"A man settles things with one big blow."

Gooooong.

The spear shaft trembled after swallowing forty-five years of internal energy.

Kraaaaaash!

A massive boulder went flying, and a tree as thick as a man was torn up by the roots.

Jeok Cheongang stood tall at the center of the clearing, which looked as though a storm had just swept through it.

He had been driven back exactly five steps.

"You—you…"

Looking half-dazed, Jeok Cheongang stared back and forth between me and the devastated surroundings.

The beautiful wilderness from moments ago had become a grotesque landscape of broken and uprooted trees and displaced boulders.

All of it was the result of a single thrust—One Annihilation.

"W-What in the world did you do?"

“Well, I’m not sure. I didn’t expect it to be this powerful either.”

It was the first time I’d used One Annihilation since reaching the Peak realm.

I’d expected its destructive power to have increased now that my internal energy had grown by leaps and bounds, but I hadn’t imagined anything like this.

Jeok Cheongang shouted at my uncertain answer.

“You think that makes any sense?”

“That’s what I’m saying. Wow, this is seriously insa—”

The world spun before my eyes, and my legs buckled.

I had poured out every last shred of strength and internal energy without leaving so much as a speck behind.

A wrinkled hand caught me as I staggered. The gaze of the man looking down at me was impossibly complex.

“I’ll hear the whole story later. Rest for now.”

As he spoke, powerful energy flowed into me through my back. It had to be internal energy that Jeok Cheongang was channeling into me.

I’d expected it to be scorching, like swallowing the sun, but his internal energy was warm and vast.

Its gentle warmth brought on an irresistible wave of drowsiness.

“O-Old Master.”

“Don’t resist. Let yourself go.”

“…Right?”

“Hm?”

“I really won, right?”

“…!”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyelids trembled. At last, he answered in a hoarse voice.

“Yes. This old man lost.”

“Heh heh heh.”

A laugh escaped me before I could stop it.

Even though the fight had been subject to countless restrictions, I was filled with joy at having made Jeok Cheongang—a master counted among the greatest under heaven—retreat.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest One Step Back was completed successfully!
Quest reward…

The fading sound of the System notification was the last thing I heard before falling into a deep sleep.

That boy. He certainly sleeps well.

Jeok Cheongang stared silently at the dead-asleep Jin Taekyung for a long while.

His strong, open features made him look like an innocent boy, yet also like a young man who had already weathered the world once over.

What a strange boy. What a strange boy indeed.

The longer Jeok Cheongang watched him, the stronger that impression became.

He had thought he'd already peeled away one layer of the boy's shell, only to discover even harder, more dazzling scales hidden beneath it.

A Hidden Dragon.

This young man, sleeping so peacefully that he was even snoring, was a dragon that had yet to obtain its dragon pearl.[1059]

That only made Jeok Cheongang more curious. How far would Jin Taekyung go? Would he live long enough to see the boy's true limits?

Especially that final strike…

Jeok Cheongang looked around once more and let out a hollow laugh.

Could this really be the work of a young prodigy who had only just passed twenty?

He was certain that even the Sword Saint of years past had not been capable of this much.

The Martial God. Perhaps he could have done it.

A martial artist born human, yet called a god. The one person who had ever inspired awe in Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

What had he been like in his youth—the man revered not merely as the greatest under heaven, but as the greatest of all time?

As Jeok Cheongang imagined Jin Taekyung as he was now alongside the Martial God in his youth, a quiet laugh escaped him.

For this old man to entertain such a thought… The boy's talent must truly be great enough to compare with the Martial God's.

Jeok Cheongang gazed deeply at Jin Taekyung, then rose to his feet.

By now, a desire was rapidly taking root within him—the desire to place a dragon pearl[1060] in the hands of this young Hidden Dragon.

Fly freely above the clouds. Become a Heavenly Dragon capable of covering the world with rain and wind.

Grrrrrk.

[1059] A dragon pearl is a legendary treasure associated with dragons in East Asian folklore.

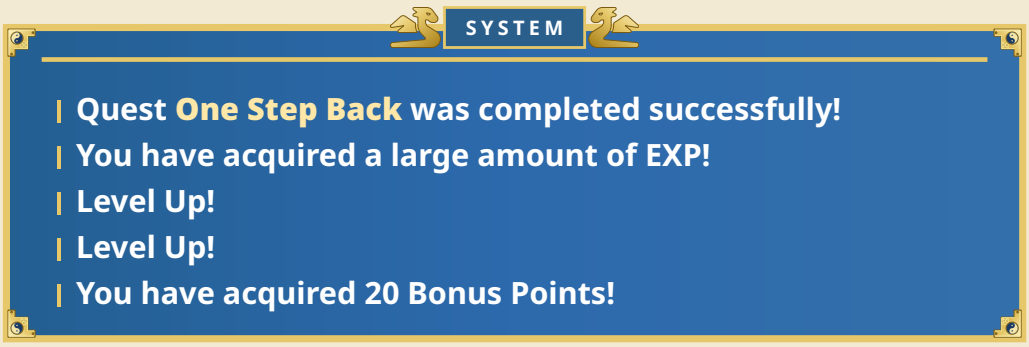
[1060] A dragon pearl is a legendary treasure associated with dragons in East Asian folklore.

At the snore that came instead of an answer, Jeok Cheongang burst into hearty laughter.

Chapter 203

I read through the System message floating before my eyes.

It was the Quest reward notification I hadn't gotten a chance to check before passing out.



That's insanely generous.

Two level-ups, plus bonus points. All told, a single Quest had given me the equivalent of roughly four levels.

Maybe the reward was bigger than expected because of who my opponent had been.

Close window.

Shhk.

The translucent holographic window disappeared, revealing Jeok Cheongang walking toward me.

He held the satchel he had brought with him.

"Are you awake?"

"Ah, yes. Just woke up."

"How does your body feel?"

"Light as a feather."

Jeok Cheongang looked me up and down, then nodded.

"I suppose young men really do recover quickly. We can move straight on to the next step."

"Ah, the next step. Sounds good."

"I knew you'd say that. This old man prepared something perfect for you. Let's see…"

"Old Master."

"Hm?"

"I mean, that's all well and good, but…"

I gave him an awkward smile.

"Could you release my acupoints before we start?"

I meant that literally.

I had no idea what had happened, but my entire body had been frozen stiff ever since I opened my eyes.

Jeok Cheongang had struck my Paralysis Acupoint while I was asleep.

As things stood, the most I could do was speak.

“I’m sure you meant well, but we should probably get started on the next round of training… Heh heh.”

“Ah, yes. Training.”

Jeok Cheongang rummaged through the satchel.

“This is the next round of training.”

“Getting my acupoints sealed is training?”

Or was releasing them supposed to be the training?

While I was trying to figure that out, Jeok Cheongang pulled something from the satchel.

“Here it is. I forgot I’d stuffed it all the way at the bottom.”

“…Isn’t that a rope?”

“That’s right.”

He slung the sturdy rope over his shoulder, strode over, and hoisted me into the air.

“W-Wait. What are you doing?”

“You’ll find out soon enough.”

He carried me toward a massive boulder.

It had been lodged deep in the earth for who knew how long and was so large that several grown men with their arms outstretched couldn’t have encircled it.

“Hmm. This should do.”

Jeok Cheongang muttered under his breath and brought the edge of his hand down on the boulder.

Shhk. Shhk.

The red Force around his hand sliced the enormous boulder apart like cheesecake. After only a few cuts, he had transformed it into a five-star stone bed.

“This should be just right.”

“W-Wait a second. You’re not planning to tie me to this thing, are you?”

“Tie you? I’m securing you.”

“…”

How was that any different from calling shit *feces*?

At any rate, I was beginning to tremble.

Actually, the Paralysis Acupoint had been suspicious enough from the beginning. So was the satchel Jeok Cheongang had been rummaging through this whole time.

He’s not actually going to pull out a whip and a mask, is he?

While my pupils quaked, Jeok Cheongang began securing me to the boulder with the rope.

He wound it around various parts of my body, tied it tight, then smiled in satisfaction.

“This should keep you from falling off.”

“Phew.”

“What was that sigh of relief for?”

“I’m relieved it isn’t a tortoise-shell knot.[1061]”

“A tortoise-shell knot? What’s that?”

“…A type of restraint technique.”

“Restraint? Something they use in the military, I take it.”

“…”

Mostly Japanese guys use it.

Well, whatever.

I was now tied down with my arms and legs spread wide.

Both wrists, both ankles, my chest, stomach, and legs. It really did look as though he was trying to secure me rather than restrain me.

Then again, he already struck my Paralysis Acupoint. There’s no need to tie me up that tightly.

But what the hell was he planning to do?

As my eyes darted around, Jeok Cheongang finally opened the satchel.

At that very moment—

Whoosh!

“Gasp.”

An indescribable fragrance burst from it.

A crisp, refreshing sensation entered through my nose and spread throughout my body, strong enough to cure a chronic case of rhinitis on the spot.

My eyes widened as I stared at the objects inside.

“These are…”

Three roots lay neatly arranged within the satchel.

Jeok Cheongang picked up the reddish roots and laid them across his palm.

“Elixirs.”

“Whoa. Where did you find something this valuable?”

“I searched the storehouse. It was packed to the rafters with useless junk, so finding them was a damn nuisance.”

[1061] A tortoise-shell knot is a decorative rope-binding pattern associated with Japanese bondage.

Mountains of silk, gold, silver, and jewels were nothing but worthless clutter in his eyes.

But he was a martial artist to his very bones. Elixirs or martial arts manuals that could improve his martial arts were another matter entirely.

"To be honest, these elixirs aren't especially potent. If all you wanted was more internal energy, a hundred-year-old He Shou Wu[1062] or snow ginseng would be far better."

"Then why…"

"You're wondering why I bothered bringing these?"

"Yes."

"Because only these can provide pure Scorching Yang Qi. Swallowing every elixir you can find might increase the amount of your internal energy, but its power would suffer."

"Oh."

I thought I understood what he meant.

Put simply, it was a matter of fuel. You could pile on all the firewood you wanted, but oil was what made a fire explode.

What he held wasn't firewood. It was oil that would further strengthen the Scorching Yang Qi already inside me.

Still, I'm touched.

I hadn't expected Jeok Cheongang to go this far for me.

For a man as cantankerous as him to endure the hassle of personally selecting and bringing me elixirs filled with Scorching Yang Qi could only mean that he truly intended to teach me the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts.

And I'm not even officially his Disciple yet.

A man with a warm heart and warm internal energy.

That was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

When he met my heated gaze, he flinched and took a step back.

"W-What's with that stare?"

"Nothing. You just seem like a really good person, Old Master."

"…!"

"You brought those for me to eat, right?"

Jeok Cheongang hesitated before answering.

"…They merely caught my eye, so I brought them along."

"I see."

"This old man kept the better ones for himself."

"Yes. Heh heh."

[1062] *He Shou Wu* is a medicinal herb used in traditional Chinese medicine.

"Stop laughing!"

Jeok Cheongang barked, then hastily changed the subject.

"A-Anyway, this old man will now use these elixirs to open your acupoints."

I had been thinking of teasing him a little more, but what he'd just said sounded serious. My ears perked up before I knew it.

"You're going to open my acupoints?"

"You heard me. When this old man examined your body before, your muscles and bones were exceptional, just as one would expect of the Heavenly Martial Physique, but you had a considerable amount of turbid qi inside you."

"Oh."

"I heard that until recently, you spent your life drowning in wine and women. Even the finest sword will lose its edge if neglected for too long. The Heavenly Martial Physique is no exception."

I couldn't deny it.

The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was extremely stable, but it lacked power and efficiency when circulating internal energy.

I circulated my qi whenever I had the chance, but the traces left by twenty years of slacking off had yet to disappear.

"Then…"

"This old man will use the elixirs and my internal energy to burn every last bit of turbid qi from your body. For you, it should be far more effective than cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow.[1063]"

"That's welcome news."

"I doubt you'll find it quite so welcome."

"What?"

"You'll find out soon enough."

Before I could say anything else, he sealed my Mute Acupoint. My tongue went rigid, trapping a silent cry inside my mouth.

What the hell is this?

Now I really was a corpse with its eyes open.

Jeok Cheongang grinned down at me as I lay frozen like a plaster statue.

"First, let's get those elixirs into you."

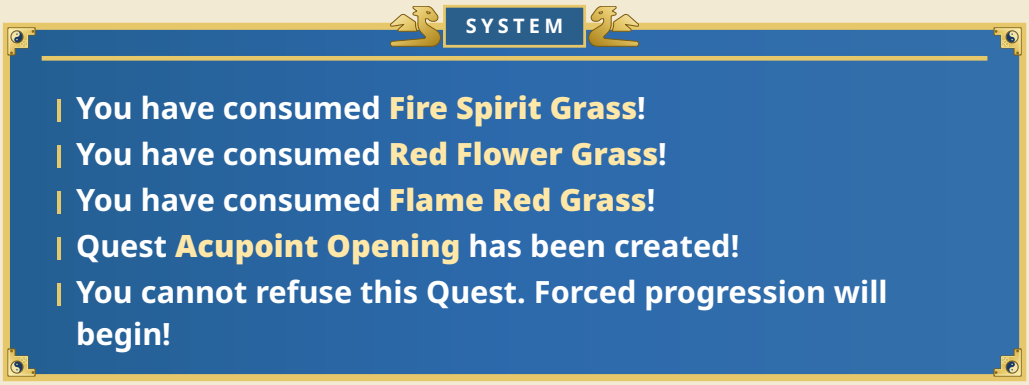
His wrinkled fingers pried open my jaw and slipped all three roots into my mouth.

For a moment, the taste of dirt and a crisp coolness filled my mouth. Then the hard roots melted the instant they touched my tongue and flowed down my throat into my stomach.

The next moment—

[1063] "Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow" refers to a martial technique intended to improve the body's constitution.

Ding.



Gah!

System notifications rang out one after another as tremendous heat swept through my body.

Only then did I understand what Jeok Cheongang had meant.

It fucking hurts!

With my acupoints sealed, I couldn't scream or thrash around. All I could do was stare wide-eyed.

Just as I hurriedly tried to draw up my internal energy, Jeok Cheongang rolled up his worn sleeves.

"All right, then. Shall we begin in earnest?"

"...!"

"Bear with it, no matter how much it hurts. Pain is temporary, but martial arts last a lifetime."

Tap. Tap-tap-tap-tap!

His fingers blurred as they jabbed and tapped all over my body.

Each impact scattered my internal energy, allowing the unfamiliar energy of the elixirs to race through me. Trapped in the boiling heat, I screamed without a sound.

AAAAAAAAARGH!

Unlike Jin Taekyung's bloodshot eyes, strained by unbearable pain, Jeok Cheongang's gleamed with fervor.

It's proceeding smoothly. No, explosively.

Was this the Heavenly Martial Physique at work?

The speed at which the internal energy spread was astonishing. The more than thirty years of energy contained within the elixirs ran wild through every minor meridian in Jin Taekyung's body.

Jin Taekyung tried to raise his own internal energy and suppress it, but that was not what Jeok Cheongang wanted.

He can tame it later. For now, it must be allowed to run wild.

A tamed fighting bull sometimes forgot how to charge.

The newly infused energy of thirty years had to break through everything in its path without restriction.

The attempt was dangerous enough that a single mistake could cause qi deviation. Even Jeok Cheongang, a Supreme Peak master, swallowed dryly as his fingers continued to move.

Gyeonjeong, Amun, Bongan, Ip-dong…

Tap. Tap-tap!

Following his guidance, hundreds of acupoints opened and closed over and over. Before long, black sweat poured from Jin Taekyung's entire body, accompanied by a musty odor.

The stench was vile enough to make even someone with an iron stomach gag, but the corners of Jeok Cheongang's mouth twitched with delight.

It worked!

This was proof that a tremendous amount of turbid qi was being expelled.

As if to confirm his conclusion, the sweat gradually lightened and the stench slowly faded.

Before long, the sweat became clear, and a pleasant body scent wafted through the air. Astonishment filled Jeok Cheongang's eyes.

Already?

It was fast. Far too fast.

The process he had expected to take at least three shichen[1064] was already nearing completion in less than one.

Even more astonishing was the fact that the energy of the elixirs had barely diminished.

Ordinarily, a considerable amount of energy would be lost in the process of purging the turbid qi and circulating what remained.

Jin Taekyung was different.

As expected of the Heavenly Martial Physique… It truly lives up to its name.

At this rate, he could remove all the turbid qi and still gain the full thirty years of internal energy.

Yet instead of satisfaction, greed and indecision filled Jeok Cheongang's eyes.

What if we push further?

The Conception Vessel and the Governor Vessel—the mountain known collectively as the Conception and Governor Vessels.

[1064] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

It was a realm most martial artists of the Murim could not reach even after devoting their entire lives to training.

Breaking through it required both enormous internal energy and enlightenment, but it might be possible now.

The Heavenly Martial Physique. And my help.

Even so, attempting to open the Conception and Governor Vessels at once was dangerous.

Leaving everything else aside, Jeok Cheongang's greatest concern was whether Jin Taekyung could withstand the pain.

What should I do?

After agonizing over it again and again, Jeok Cheongang finally spoke.

"I think you can open the Conception and Governor Vessels."

"…!"

Jin Taekyung's bloodshot eyes trembled as he endured the pain. Unable to answer, he could only listen as Jeok Cheongang continued.

"But you'll have to accept the risks that come with it. The pain will likely be beyond anything you've experienced so far. A single mistake could cost you your life."

"…"

"The choice is yours. If you trust this old man and wish to leave it in my hands, blink twice."

The next moment, Jin Taekyung blinked without hesitation.

Two blinks, without the slightest trace of doubt.

Seeing the unwavering trust in his eyes, Jeok Cheongang felt something warm rise within his chest.

Has this brat truly trusted me that deeply?

Suppressing the swell of emotion, he forced the corners of his mouth upward.

"All right. Let's give it a try."

At the same time, an immense torrent of internal energy flowed from his fingertips into Jin Taekyung's body.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Information for Quest Acupoint Opening has changed!
Quest Conception and Governor Vessels has been created! The difficulty and rewards have been adjusted to reflect the updated information!

As I listened to the System notification, one thought crossed my mind.

No, fuck…

I was sure I'd only blinked once.

Chapter 204

Whooosh!

A tremendous surge of internal energy began racing along the path.

Opening the Conception Vessel required passing through a pathway of twenty-four acupoints, beginning with the Huiyin Acupoint.

The problem was that the Huiyin Acupoint happened to be located in a rather important part of the body.

No. No!

A forced opening?!

No scream escaped my lips. The internal energy transformed into a raging bull and slammed into the Huiyin Acupoint.

Boom!

…!

It was a sensation only someone who had experienced it could understand. My vision went white as though I'd arrived in heaven, and all my senses faded away.

The faces of those dearest to me flashed before my eyes one after another.

Mom. Hayeon. And among them, the unfamiliar face of a newborn baby.

Y-You're…

Waaaaah!

A baby's cry echoed through my head like an auditory hallucination.

Only then did I realize who it was.

Oh, my baby!

Jin Taekyung Junior, whom I had yet to meet.

The child I might now never meet at all.

The baby's innocent eyes seemed to ask me:

"Daddy, can't I come out?"

The next moment, my vision returned—and unimaginable pain shot straight up from my lower body.

Kyaaaaaaah!

As I screamed from the depths of my soul, an urgent voice lashed my ears.

"Get a hold of yourself! If you can't endure this pain, you'll die!"

…!

Death? Me? And in such a disgraceful way?

My mind snapped back into focus as if someone had dumped cold water over my head.

The pain stabbing into my lower abdomen like a knife hadn't lessened, but I summoned superhuman endurance.

I can't die like this!

I had survived countless bloody battles. Even when I'd suffered injuries severe enough to threaten my life, I'd gritted my teeth and held on.

This was only this much—no, it wasn't *only* this much, but still, I wasn't so impatient that I'd let my life end over something like this.

Hng!

As I endured with everything I had, the tremendous surge of internal energy tore through the twenty-four acupoints without pause.

And finally…

Boom!

It crashed into the gate known as the Conception Vessel.

Pain nearly as intense as what I'd felt at the Huiyin Acupoint surged through me like a wave.

The difference was that this collision didn't end with a single blow.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Once, twice, three times. Thunderous booms and vibrations rang out inside my body like thunder from the heavens.

Only then did I understand why Jeok Cheongang had pressed my Paralysis Acupoint and Mute Acupoint. And why he had secured me with ropes on top of that.

Gnnngh!

My entire body trembled despite my sealed acupoints. Faced with pain beyond anything it could bear, my body was reacting on its own.

Pop.

The tiny blood vessels in my wide-open eyes burst.

Through my blood-red vision, I saw Jeok Cheongang roaring.

"Endure it! This is the last one!"

The last one? Really?

Whether it was true or not didn't matter. His words gave me strength.

Just a little more. More!

I drew up the internal energy lying dormant in my dantian.

Forty-five years of internal energy raced through the wide-open acupoint pathways, where all the turbid qi and obstacles had been removed, and surged upward in one burst.

Then it joined the elixir's energy, which was already pounding against the Conception Vessel, and Jeok Cheongang's internal energy.

The three energies merged into a single battering ram and struck the gate with greater force and sharpness than ever before.

Bang! Kwoooong!

That blow put an end to it.

The long struggle was over.

The tightly sealed Conception Vessel crumbled, and the energies poured through like a conquering army.

For an instant, dizzying pain swept through me. Then pleasure and exhilarating clarity several times more intense than that pain flooded my entire body.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have successfully opened the Conception Vessel!
The handling of qi has become much freer!
Your speed of circulating and accumulating internal energy has increased dramatically!
You have achieved the Conception Vessel Opening Achievement!
As a reward...

Ah... Ahhh!

My body trembled, no longer from pain but from sheer joy.

This was different. Everything I'd known until now had been no more than a drop in the ocean.

The difference was as vast as the gulf between First Rate and Peak.

How can it change this much?

I'd suffered unimaginable pain, but an achievement like this was worth it. No—I had to endure it.

As I marveled at the transformation, Jeok Cheongang beamed at me.

"You did very well!"

Seeing how genuinely delighted he was made something stir deep in my chest.

I couldn't believe he had gone so far to help me. If my acupoints hadn't been sealed, I would have dropped to the ground and given Jeok Cheongang a deep bow.

Jeok Cheongang, you really...

Just as my eyes began to grow moist, he spoke.

"We can open the Governor Vessel the same way."

"..."

Oh, fuck.

I forgot about that.

He wants me to do this all over again?

No. I'm not doing it! At least let me rest for a while first!

Jeok Cheongang chuckled as I blinked desperately.

“You’re beside yourself with eagerness to begin at once. I was going to let you rest for a while, but… Very well. Let’s ride this momentum and open both the Conception and Governor Vessels!”

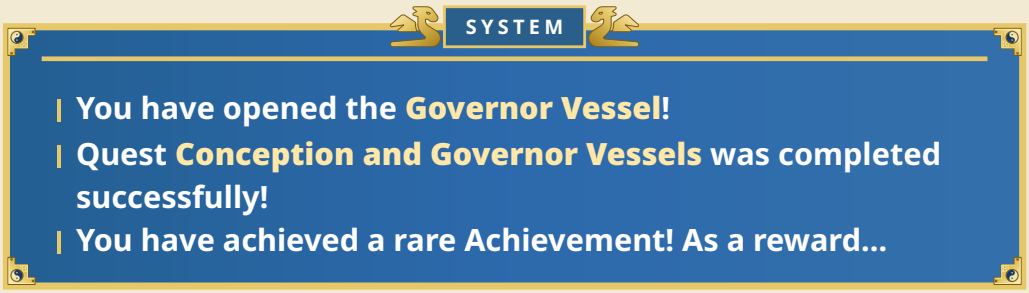
…!

“Here we go!”

And so, the express train to hell departed once more.

One shichen later,[1065] I faintly heard a System notification through the haze clouding my mind.

Ding.



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Whatever. Fuck this.

To hell with rare Achievements and everything else. I couldn’t take any more.

Having exhausted every last shred of mental strength, I plunged headfirst into endless darkness.

The moment Jeok Cheongang loosened the ropes, Jin Taekyung’s collapsing body fell into his careful embrace.

The sweat Taekyung had shed while enduring the pain and the turbid qi expelled from his body earlier combined into a terrible stench, but Jeok Cheongang didn’t care.

They were the traces left by a martial artist striving to reach a higher realm.

Jeok Cheongang gazed down at the unconscious Jin Taekyung with eyes deeper and gentler than ever.

The more I learn about him, the more remarkable he becomes.

At first, Jeok Cheongang had wondered one thing.

Why him, of all people?

[1065] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

In his eyes, Jin Taekyung had been neither white nor black. He was gray—the same ordinary gray found everywhere in the world.

He wasn't exactly burning with a sense of justice, but neither was he evil.

Nor was he particularly devoted to training in martial arts.

From the moment Jeok Cheongang arrived at the Jin Family of Taiyuan, he'd heard about Jin Taekyung until his ears ached.

He hadn't even needed to ask. Everyone around him was always talking about the boy.

His martial arts were Third Rate, while his drinking, womanizing, and gambling were First Rate. Unlike his two gifted older brothers, he had been called a disgrace to the family.

Upon learning that, Jeok Cheongang had resented the heavens, if only for a moment.

Why did you give the Heavenly Martial Physique to someone like him?

A fine sword ought to belong to a swordsman, not a farmer.

Yet the Jin Taekyung of the rumors was no different from a farmer holding a fine sword. Worse, he didn't even possess a farmer's diligence.

The only pursuits he approached diligently were drinking, womanizing, and gambling. What more was there to say?

But…

I was wrong.

Looking back, Jeok Cheongang realized that everything he had thought was merely an old man's stubborn prejudice and contradiction.

He was no immortal sage. How could he divide someone he'd only just met into black or white? And what did it matter if Taekyung was gray?

A human heart. As long as he keeps hold of that, it is enough.

Judging by everything Jeok Cheongang had seen so far, Jin Taekyung was a decent young man.

Humans were imperfect beings to begin with. Trying to divide them into perfect white and black was absurd.

Perhaps gray was merely another name for a good person.

And on top of that, he possesses remarkable mental strength.

What good was being born with a fine physique? Opening the Conception and Governor Vessels was so difficult and agonizing that the process could only be called hellish.

Yet Jin Taekyung had done it—and done it splendidly.

It must have been unbearably difficult and painful. Even so, he had endured through sheer determination to become stronger.

Jin Taekyung possessed a mental strength as firm as his physique.

The Heavenly Martial Physique chose its master well.

A satisfied smile appeared around Jeok Cheongang's mouth. After gazing at Jin Taekyung for a long while, he muttered:

"Perhaps… it may happen much sooner than I thought."

As soon as he finished speaking, Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled fingers began to tremble.

Even for him, the process had consumed a considerable amount of internal energy and mental strength. Before his mind could fully register the toll, his aging body had already made it clear.

"Not yet, you bastard. Hold out for just a few more years."

Jeok Cheongang muttered bitterly and lifted Jin Taekyung into his arms.

They had crossed a great mountain. Now it was time to rest.

For the young man and the old man alike.

It was around noon when Ak Bulgun, a spear instructor at Heaven's Gate Temple, arrived at Jin Wikyung's office.

When he opened the door and entered, Jin Wikyung, who had been scribbling something across a bamboo slip, brightened and rose from his seat.

"Sir Ak, welcome. Thank you for accepting my invitation despite how busy you must be."

"It only makes sense for the man with more time on his hands to make the trip. Please don't concern yourself with it."

The Shandong Yue Family was renowned throughout the Murim as a prestigious family of spear masters.

Yet despite being a direct descendant of such an illustrious family, Ak Bulgun was a straightforward man with little patience for empty formalities.

That personality showed plainly when he got straight to the point without even pausing for a sip of tea.

"Why did you summon me? Could it be…"

Jin Wikyung smiled faintly.

"Unfortunately, this isn't about Mukyung."

"I see."

Ak Bulgun nodded, then added bluntly,

"Lesser Family Head, please understand that Heaven's Gate Temple enforces its rules strictly."

Heaven's Gate Temple was both a treasure trove of outstanding talent and a gateway to advancement.

Anyone with sufficient talent could become a cadet regardless of their background. Its members consequently ranged from disciples of small sects in remote regions to the disciples and scions of prestigious major sects.

Despite bringing together people from such disparate backgrounds, Heaven's Gate Temple had avoided serious conflict by enforcing the same strict rules upon every cadet.

"If he fails to return by the appointed date, he may be expelled. Even the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes are no exception."

"I did go to see him myself, but…"

"Did he refuse?"

"Yes."

After much deliberation, Jin Wikyung had gone to see him, but Jin Mukyung hadn't even shown his face.

According to Childeuk, the martial artist stationed at the training hall, Mukyung hadn't stepped outside once since entering.

He subsisted on fasting pills and refused to let anyone approach him. At least, when he heard that Jin Wikyung had come, he sent back a brief answer:

"I won't return until I achieve Great Completion."

Ak Bulgun let out a short laugh after hearing Jin Wikyung's explanation.

Having taught Jin Mukyung several times before, he knew the young genius's personality well.

"That sounds like him."

"It's unfortunate, but I don't think even I can overcome my little brother's stubbornness."

"The Temple Master will be just as disappointed as you are, Lesser Family Head."

Everyone had their own path to follow. Ak Bulgun nodded matter-of-factly and continued.

"I don't believe I've heard why you asked to see me."

"Ah, I wanted to deliver a message to you."

"A message?"

Instead of answering, Jin Wikyung drew a small bamboo tube from inside his robe and handed it over.

Ak Bulgun examined the characters engraved into the blue bamboo tube and murmured,

"Heaven's Gate Temple?"

"It arrived half a shichen ago.[1066] I thought it best to bring you here so I could hand it over personally."

[1066] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

“Please excuse me for a moment.”

After asking permission, Ak Bulgun silently read through the message.

He checked it twice, then a third time, before raising his head and staring at Jin Wikyung.

“Lesser Family Head.”

“…?”

“I’m going to need your help.”

Chapter 205

How long had I been unconscious?

My body felt as light as a feather, and my mind was clear. It felt as though I'd only slept for a moment, yet the world had changed a great deal while I was out.

What's going on?

The room held only simple furniture and a few decorations. The faint scent of fresh timber lingered in the recently built room.

It was a familiar sight, one I'd seen countless times before. Yet it had never felt so strange.

This is…

I looked around, my eyes trembling.

I could feel qi saturating the air, and everything around me was so bright that it was as if someone had implanted night-vision goggles in my eyes.

Even the moon beyond the latticed window seemed bizarre.

Why was the moon out when it was this bright? Wasn't that actually the sun?

I sat there in a daze for a long while, as though bewitched, before finally realizing the truth.

"Oh."

This world—the Murim—was exactly as I remembered it. Nothing had changed except me.

A small voice slipped from my lips before I realized it.

"The Conception and Governor Vessels…"

When a blocked tunnel is opened, light pours in.

Anyone accustomed to the darkness inside would naturally find that light strange. That was exactly how I felt now.

Only after removing the enormous obstacle known as the Conception and Governor Vessels could I finally see a light I'd never known existed.

"You're awake."

The owner of the sudden voice stood leaning against the doorway.

There wasn't even a lamp in the room, yet I could make out every age spot and wrinkle covering his face.

"Old Master."

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, answered as if he'd been waiting for me.

"Yeah."

"You're really old."

For a moment, he was struck speechless. I added one more thing.

"And strong. Stronger than anyone I've ever seen."

This wasn't an attempt to take back what I'd just said, nor was it empty flattery. I meant it with one hundred percent sincerity.

Now that I had opened the Conception and Governor Vessels, I could glimpse, however faintly, the terrifying martial arts hidden within that small frame.

"Ahem. You're stating the obvious."

Jeok Cheongang cleared his throat in embarrassment and changed the subject.

"So, how do you feel?"

"Fantastic."

There was no need to read a System message or circulate my internal energy to examine my body. I could feel it the moment I opened my eyes.

The corners of his mouth twitched at my immediate answer.

"Of course you do. Do you have any idea how much trouble this old man went through—no, I handled it with ease, but it's still not something just anyone could do. Indeed."

"…"

"I'm telling the truth!"

"I didn't say anything."

"That look on your face is disrespectful! That look!"

That was because his intentions were painfully obvious.

His martial arts might be unfathomable, but his personality was completely transparent.

Violent and impossibly eccentric, yet surprisingly easy to understand—that was how I saw Jeok Cheongang.

"I have ptosis, so people often misunderstand my expression."

I put on an utterly shameless face and denied everything. Jeok Cheongang began to snort.

"Why is everyone here like this? That so-called Lesser Family Head keeps neglecting major family business to come by and see you, and those physicians are all quacks who do nothing but gossip about whether you're going to live or die."

"Wait. Die? Did someone get seriously hurt?"

"Who else would it be?"

At his meaningful stare, I asked with a sinking feeling:

"Are you talking about me?"

"That's right. The whole place was in an uproar for the past seven days and nights. If I'd known this would happen, I would've shoved you under a rock until you came to your senses."

I didn't even hear the rest. I blinked at him in a daze.

"I was unconscious for seven whole days and nights?"

"Not *seven whole days and nights*. Only seven. I thought you'd be lying there for at least a month, but the Heavenly Martial Physique truly is remarkable."

"This isn't some kind of side effect, is it?"

"Listen to the insolence in this brat's voice. I went through all that trouble to open your Conception and Governor Vessels, and what do I get? 'Side effect'?"

"You just said you handled it with ease."

Jeok Cheongang froze, then shouted:

"That's beside the point! Even after you take a shit, you still have to wipe your ass. I removed all the turbid qi that had been piling up inside your body, layer upon layer. Obviously, you'd need time to adjust to your new body!"

"…"

He was so worked up that the analogy was a little strange, but I understood what he meant.

Some kind of optimization process, maybe?

Come to think of it, it would be strange for someone on the verge of death to leap to his feet just because his Conception and Governor Vessels had been opened. Even after leveling up, mental fatigue could still build up and knock a person unconscious.

Even so, an entire week?

"Then the gathering must be over."

"The gathering—or half a gathering—ended three days ago."

Still visibly sulking, Jeok Cheongang continued:

"That fellow Ak Bulgun is still here."

I tilted my head at the unexpected name.

Ak Bulgun, an instructor at Heaven's Gate Temple, had originally come to the Jin Family of Taiyuan to take Jin Mukyung back.

Could he really be planning to wait until Jin Mukyung finished his seclusion?

"Why is Sir Ak still here?"

"Ask him yourself."

"Come on. I was wrong, so stop being angry and tell me."

Jeok Cheongang replied curtly:

"Do I look that petty to you? I mean he's on his way here, so you can hear it directly from him."

"Oh."

Sure enough, he was right. Not long afterward, approaching footsteps announced the arrival of two people.

"My youngest!"

Jin Wikyung's voice trembled with emotion when he saw that I had awakened after seven days and nights. Behind him came Ak Bulgun's blunt voice.

“It seems Great Hero Jeok is here as well. I have something important to discuss with you. Would that be all right?”

Jeok Cheongang answered firmly:

“No. Get out.”

“It concerns Jin Taekyung’s plans as well.”

“…Damn it.”

Jeok Cheongang muttered a quiet curse and perched on a chair.

As his appearance suggested, Ak Bulgun was not much of an orator. After listening to his entire dry explanation, I spoke.

“So you’re inviting us to that… Star… Star-Array…”

What was it called again? His explanation had been so boring that I could barely remember what I’d heard.

When I faltered, Jeok Cheongang supplied the name.

“The Star-Array Grand Banquet.”

“Ah, right. The Star-Array Grand Banquet.”

“It is a grand event where martial artists from across the world gather in one place to vie for supremacy and reinforce their bonds. It is held once every two or three years, and this year’s Star-Array Grand Banquet will take place in Henan.”

At Ak Bulgun’s additional explanation, Jeok Cheongang gave a derisive laugh.

“Reinforce the bonds of the Murim, my ass. It’s a place where powerful people cheer each other on, flatter one another, and build connections.”

Talk about a mercilessly blunt assessment.

Ak Bulgun gave a small nod without offering any real objection. It seemed Jeok Cheongang wasn’t wrong.

Jeok Cheongang continued in a cutting tone:

“It was the same forty years ago. The Demonic Cult had barely been driven out, and already they were fighting over their interests… I saw more than enough ugliness.”

I could more or less picture what it had been like.

A time of chaos was also a time of opportunity. The greedy and powerful never let an opportunity pass them by.

It might even have been partly related to why Jeok Cheongang had gone into seclusion on Mount Jiuhua again.

Still, it sounds like an enormous event.

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes at my curious stare.

“What are you looking at?”

“It’s nothing. I was just wondering why someone who hates crowds and anything troublesome would go to a place like that.”

“I was asked to.”

“…?”

Was Jeok Cheongang really the sort of person to comply simply because someone asked him to?

The question vanished as soon as I heard the title of the person who had asked.

“The Martial God.”

“Oh.”

The Martial God, whom I’d only ever heard about.

They said there were Ten Kings on earth, Three Saints in the heavens, and one god above them all.

If the request had come from that Martial God, even Jeok Cheongang probably couldn’t have refused easily.

“He was the one who created the Star-Array Grand Banquet and asked this old man to attend. That was the first and last time the One God, Three Saints, and Ten Kings gathered in one place.”

As though recalling those days, Jeok Cheongang tapped the armrest of his chair with a distant look in his eyes. Then he suddenly turned to Ak Bulgun.

“How is he doing?”

“He has not shown himself for many years. There are even disturbing rumors circulating…”

“You’re worried the Martial God might be dead? Ha. There are far too many idiots with nothing but shit in their heads.”

Jeok Cheongang let out a hollow laugh, then turned back to me.

“So, what do you think?”

“Hmm.”

“Even if it is a feast for the powerful, there is no denying that the Star-Array Grand Banquet is a gathering of martial artists from across the world. Anyone can display their abilities to the fullest, regardless of their background.”

“I’m not sure.”

I scratched the back of my head, unable to answer easily.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet. A gathering where martial artists from across the world assembled to reinforce their bonds and vie for supremacy.

It was a chance to face outstanding masters and make a name for myself throughout the Central Plains.

But…

Was that really so important?

Ever since coming to the Murim, I'd found myself wondering about that from time to time.

Why did I practice martial arts? Why did I keep training even after becoming strong enough to protect my own life and the people precious to me?

After thinking about it for a long time, I'd finally found the answer not long ago.

Because it's fun.

Just as I'd told Cheongpung, I liked martial arts. They were fun.

Even if I gained more money and fame than I could possibly imagine, I would never stop training.

I was already addicted to martial arts. I'd discovered just how thrilling and satisfying it was to become stronger.

"Young Hero Jin."

Ak Bulgun's quiet voice broke through my thoughts. It was time to answer.

I took a deep breath and opened my mouth.

"I…"

The expressions of all three men changed strangely when they heard my answer.

The three men left.

Alone in the room, I thought back to my final exchange with Jeok Cheongang.

You want to become stronger. Is that your answer?

Yes.

Does that mean you'll attend the Star-Array Grand Banquet?

It doesn't matter where I go, as long as I can become stronger than I am now.

You're still young, and you're already strong enough. If you attend the Star-Array Grand Banquet, you could etch your name into the Murim and gain wealth and fame. Aren't you tempted by those things?

I am. By martial arts. By a higher realm.

…!

Jeok Cheongang had stared at me with trembling eyes for a long while before leaving me with a single command.

Come to my quarters at dawn.

Remembering his final words, I sat down on the bed.

My field of vision was as bright as midday, and I could hear the footsteps and breathing of people outside the pavilion as clearly as if they were right beside me.

You're already strong enough.

Jeok Cheongang himself had said those words before leaving. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, had acknowledged me.

But there was something else I wanted to hear.

You're stronger than anyone.

Back when I was an F-rank Hunter, my wish had been to become an E-rank Hunter. When I first set foot in the Murim, my goal had been to surpass Hyuk Mujin.

As time passed, I grew stronger, and my dreams grew more ambitious.

Some people might call that greed. But greed and dreams were different.

I had a dream now. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was the guide who could lead me toward it.

I'm looking forward to morning.

There were roughly three shichen[1067] left until dawn.

It looked like tonight would be a long one—for both me and Jeok Cheongang.

Especially for me. It'll be a night longer than I can even imagine.

I lay flat on my back.

It was time to leave behind everything that had happened in the Murim and return.

Logout.

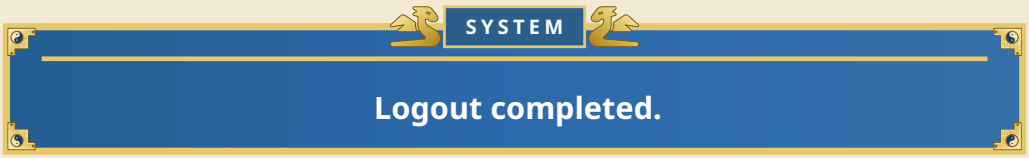
Ding.

With the cheerful System notification, my eyes slowly closed.

[1067] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

Chapter 206

Ding.



I hadn't opened my eyes, but I knew.

The moment the System notification sounded, everything around me changed.

Instead of a fur-covered bed and a hard wooden pillow, I felt the soft cushions of a sofa beneath me. Water bubbled nearby, and a familiar smell hit my nose.

Th-This is…

Ramen. And not just any ramen—ramen cooked to perfection!

The instant I realized what it was, my stomach began churning violently. After more than a month in the Murim, it was desperate for seasoning.

"I'm hungry!"

The cry came straight from my soul. My eyes snapped open, and a familiar face popped out from the brightly lit kitchen.

Sparse stubble. Greasy, matted hair. Jinho wiped his steam-fogged glasses and beamed at me.

"Oh, my beloved little brother Taekyung. Did you sleep well?"

His revoltingly sweet tone was nothing like his usual voice, but the smell of ramen had already driven me out of my mind.

"Ramen!"

"Jesus, what's gotten into you?"

"Kimchi[1068]!"

"You were really out cold. I was going to shake you awake, but…"

"Cold rice! At least five bowls!"

"…Uh, all right. I was about to bring it over anyway."

A short while later, I stared at the pot filled to the brim with noodles and broth and murmured in bliss.

"This is insane…"

"Lift the top layer of noodles a little. There's a soft-boiled egg underneath."

"Gasp."

Just as he'd said, when I carefully lifted the noodles, a perfectly intact soft-boiled egg appeared beneath them.

[1068] *Kimchi* is a Korean side dish of fermented vegetables, commonly napa cabbage, seasoned with chili and other ingredients.

As I sucked in a breath, Jinho held out two small side dishes.

“Here. Kimchi[1069] and pickled radish. The rice is plain white rice I took out an hour ago. Once you finish the noodles and drink a few mouthfuls of broth, drop in the cold rice and…”

“Are you…”

“Hm?”

“Are you God?”

Jinho placed an exam-prep book beneath the pot and answered solemnly.

“Genesis, chapter one, verse one. Thus spoke Seong Jinho: ‘If you do not eat now, the broth shall grow cold, and the noodles shall become hopelessly soggy.‘”

“Ah… Ahhh…”

“Little lamb, why dost thou flap thy gums with ramen before thee? Lick the pot clean and leave not a single drop of broth behind.”

I’d been nonreligious my entire life.

Not anymore.

I gazed reverently up at Jinho and raised my chopsticks.

“Amen.”

“Ramen.”

Today, I wouldn’t have minded dying with my nose buried in ramen broth.

I buried my head over the huge pot and moved my chopsticks without pause. Because the distance between my mouth and the chopsticks was so short, the noodles kept disappearing into me.

Slurp! Slurp! Slurrrrrp!

Springy noodles. Spicy broth. When I broke open the soft-boiled egg, the bliss and regret were so overwhelming that a single tear rolled down my cheek.

It’s delicious. So delicious.

I love seasoning. It’s the best.

Drunk on that artificial flavor found only in the modern world, I kept inhaling food.

By the time I came to my senses, there was nothing in front of me but an empty pot and bowls. Even the bowl that had held a heaping mound of cold rice was spotless.

“Buuurp.”

“You’ve got to be kidding me.”

Jinho stared at me in horror as I rubbed my stomach and let out a tremendous belch.

[1069] *Kimchi* is a Korean side dish of fermented vegetables, commonly napa cabbage, seasoned with chili and other ingredients.

“You ate seven packets of ramen and five bowls of rice by yourself in ten minutes? Are you even human?”

“Carbonation! Cola!”

“…C-Calm down. I’ll get some.”

Only after draining three 1.5-liter[1070] bottles of cola in a row did I finally return to something resembling sanity.

“Whew. That hit the spot. I’m full.”

“That’s strange. Why am I hungry?”

“Bear with it. You would’ve done the same if you were me.”

I answered absently and collapsed back against the sofa behind me.

What kind of monster hide had they said this was made from? Whatever it was, it felt incredible.

“Man, this is comfortable.”

If this had been my goshiwon[1071] room, there wouldn’t even have been space for a sofa.

Jinho would have had to cook the ramen in the communal lounge instead of a kitchen, or bring in a portable burner.

“Moving here really was the right choice.”

Jinho scraped the bottom of the pot with a spoon as he answered.

“Yeah. It’s a nice place.”

“Right? Mom and Hayeon are going to love it when they see… it.”

A realization flashed through my mind like lightning.

I stared blankly around the room, my mouth hanging open. The space and furniture were nothing like what I’d had in the goshiwon[1072].

And one particular person had blended seamlessly into both the space and the situation.

“I’m still hungry. Should I make some Jjapagetti[1073]?”

“…”

“I’m not giving you any this time. If you want some, say so now.”

I barely managed to squeeze out my voice.

“…You.”

“Hm?”

“Why the hell are you here, you bastard!”

My roar shattered the dark dawn and shook the residential neighborhood of Ilsan.

[1070] 1.5 liters is about 0.40 US gallons per bottle.

[1071] A *goshiwon* is a very small, inexpensive rented room, often used by students and exam candidates.

[1072] A *goshiwon* is a very small, inexpensive rented room, often used by students and exam candidates.

[1073] *Jjapagetti* is a Korean brand of instant noodles flavored like black-bean-sauce noodles.

After hearing the whole story, I could only ask in disbelief.

“You were inside the capsule?”

Jinho knelt politely with both arms raised above his head and looked away.

“Yeah. I held my breath and stayed perfectly still.”

No wonder the mover had struggled so much.

Even I hadn’t noticed anything unusual. My Strength had grown several times over since I’d first found and moved the capsule, and my Qi Sense hadn’t been nearly as sharp back then as it was now.

And there was one more thing.

No, for fuck’s sake. Who would’ve imagined that?

No matter how expensive or sophisticated an alarm system was, it couldn’t detect an intruder when the power was off.

It had never even occurred to me that someone might be hiding inside the capsule.

“Whew. What happened to the place you were going to get? Didn’t you say you were moving in with a friend?”

“Y-You know Kim Jong-su, right? My college classmate. You had drinks with us once a couple of years ago.”

His face was hazy in my memory, but I did remember that.

Hadn’t he been a fairly successful used-car dealer at the time? If he hadn’t bought us beef that day, I probably would’ve forgotten him completely.

“That’s the friend you were going to live with?”

“Yeah. Though he’s not my friend anymore.”

“Hyung[1074], did he…?”

“Five million won[1075] for the deposit. That bastard took it and ran.”

Why did bad premonitions always come true?

I rubbed my throbbing forehead.

“How did that happen?”

“Well, my exam is coming up soon, so he said he’d handle all the details…”

I raised a hand to stop him before he could continue.

I didn’t need to hear the rest. It was a clichéd trick, but it kept working for a reason.

“You just handed him the money without checking anything?”

“I’d known him for over ten years. How was I supposed to know he’d do that over a few million won[1076]?”

[1074] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[1075] Five million won is about $3,600 or €3,200.

[1076] A few million won is roughly two to five million won, or about $1,400–$3,600 or €1,300–€3,200.

"But those few million won[1077] were your entire fortune, weren't they?"

"…"

If he'd gone so far as to sneak in here inside the capsule, he clearly didn't even have enough left to pay this month's goshiwon[1078] rent.

Was he from Jeju Island or something?

A special A-grade black cow.[1079]

There wasn't a bigger black cow—a bigger sucker—anywhere.

At the look in my eyes, Jinho hung his head.

"I was only going to impose on you for a couple of months, until I could scrape some money together."

"You should've just told me."

"I agonized over it, but I couldn't bring myself to say anything. I'm your hyung.[1080] I can't burden my little brother."

"…"

What the hell did this man consider a burden?

"I'm sorry. I really am."

His voice turned mournful as he lowered his arms. His eyes were already glistening.

"Taekyung…"

"Jinho hyung[1081]…"

I continued in a sympathetic voice.

"Who told you to lower your arms?"

"Hm?"

"Put them back up before I beat you."

"…Yes, sir."

Jinho hurriedly raised his arms again, and a sigh escaped me.

The whole ridiculous situation had come out of nowhere, but at the same time, it left me feeling heavyhearted.

You should've told me sooner.

Maybe I couldn't have done much for him in the past, but now I had more than enough means to help. No, even back then, I would've supported him in every way I could.

After all the time we've spent together.

[1077] A few million won is roughly two to five million won, or about $1,400–$3,600 or €1,300–€3,200.

[1078] A *goshiwon* is a very small, inexpensive rented room, often used by students and exam candidates.

[1079] "Black cow" is Korean slang for a sucker; Jeju Island is also known for its native black cattle.

[1080] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[1081] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

We weren't related by blood, but he was as good as a real brother to me. That was who Jinho was.

I'd even considered asking him to live with me for a while because I felt uneasy about leaving him on his own.

I was planning to tell Mom and Hayeon after the college entrance exam anyway, so there's still some time, but…

I looked around the house, deep in thought. It looked different from the home in my childhood memories, but it was still the house my family had finally reclaimed.

A house that still held traces of my father, whose voice had faded in my memory.

At last, I made up my mind and opened my mouth.

"This house won't work, hyung[1082]. I know you'll be disappointed, but try to understand."

Jinho forced a bright expression and shook his head.

"Why would I be disappointed? This is all my fault."

"What about your stuff? Have you unpacked?"

"Not yet. It's only a few books and some clothes, so there isn't much. I'll just leave with you when you go to work."

Come to think of it, it had been bright outside for a while. It was already eight o'clock. Between the traffic and the distance from Ilsan to Bucheon, I was cutting it pretty close.

"I think we'll have to leave separately. Get your things ready."

"Okay."

"And clean the new place from top to bottom before I get off work."

"…Huh?"

"Don't get the wrong idea. I'm not talking about this house. Give me a second."

I pulled out my phone and searched through my messages.

At last, I found the address I wanted in my chat with Team Leader Choi, whom I'd saved as "Designer-Brand Junkie."

"Ah, here it is. I just sent the address to your phone. Find your own way there."

"Wait. What address?"

"An officetel.[1083]"

"Huh?"

"The Guild offered to provide me with a place. I turned it down last time because accepting it felt like too much, but I might as well take them up on it now."

A quiet laugh escaped me when I saw Jinho's eyes widen.

"Why are you so surprised? I'm doing pretty well these days."

"…!"

[1082] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[1083] An *officetel* is a Korean building or unit designed for use as both an office and a residence.

“This house needs remodeling anyway, so let’s live there together. It’ll make my commute easier too.”

“Ta-Taekyung.”

I turned away, pretending not to hear the tremor in Jinho’s voice.

I had no desire to deal with an embarrassing scene first thing in the morning. Nor did I particularly want to be thanked by the man who had comforted me through the hardest period of my life.

It’s fine.

Yeah. This was enough.

It was mid-September. The worst of the heat had passed, but the morning commute hadn’t changed.

The taxi driver honked at the occasional inconsiderate driver cutting into traffic on the congested road, then turned up the radio.

> An F-rank Gate has appeared in Uldae-ri, Jangheung-myeon, Yangju City, and an immediate evacuation order has been issued. With nearby Hunters and military units cooperating to suppress it quickly, the confirmed number of casualties currently stands at six…

“Goddamn it. As if the traffic wasn’t bad enough, now those monster bastards are raising hell too.”

After delivering the colorful curse, he glanced at me in the passenger seat.

“You’re a Hunter too, right?”

“For now.”

At this point, I wasn’t entirely sure whether I was a Hunter or a Murim warrior.

Officially, at least in the modern world, I was a C-rank Hunter with Peace Guild.

The taxi driver grinned at my answer.

“I knew it. You can tell a Hunter at a glance.”

“I suppose so.”

It was like the difference between a herbivore and a carnivore.

There were exceptions, but everyone gave off a certain air. Someone my size carrying a large case had to be one of two things:

A musician who liked working out, or a Hunter.

You can tell at a glance.

It wasn’t anything particularly remarkable, especially for a taxi driver who met countless passengers every day.

But this middle-aged man's mouth never stopped moving.

"Hey, can I ask you something?"

"Sure."

"It feels like Gates have been opening more often lately. Can't anything be done about that?"

"…What?"

"I mean, how are ordinary people like me supposed to live without worrying? A Gate could open in my apartment parking lot the moment I wake up in the morning. What's the point of working my butt off taking fares when safe-zone land costs a fortune?"

I stared at him incredulously.

"That's true, but why are you asking me?"

"I know. I'm just frustrated, that's all. Frustrated."

"…So am I."

I was a Hunter, not a prophet.

How was I supposed to predict something even Nostradamus couldn't?

No one could predict when a Gate would form. The only reason they could suppress them quickly was because they had spent astronomical sums installing magical-power measuring devices all over the place.

Just like the breaking news now coming over the radio.

> Breaking news. The F-rank Gate reported earlier in Yangju City has been stabilized. Hunters and military forces have exterminated a total of fifty-eight goblins and are conducting a search for any remaining monsters…

"Every time you turn around, it's Gates and monsters. I'm sick to death of it."

Beep.

The taxi driver switched off the radio with an irritated jab.

An uncomfortable silence settled over the car, but I was more than happy to spend the rest of the trip in peace.

I wonder what Mom and Hayeon are doing right now.

I was gazing out the window, lost in thought, when it happened.

Honk! Hoooonk!

A faint blare pierced my ears, followed by a jumble of overlapping noises. I hurriedly rolled down the window.

What is that? Was there an accident?

The taxi driver stared at me in confusion.

"Why are you opening the window when I've got the air conditioner on—"

"Wait. Just give me a second."

My serious tone silenced him. I drew up my internal energy.

My hearing and vision, already far beyond the limits of an ordinary human, swept across the congested road.

“Huh?”

Far in the distance, a black dot shot into the air.

It began to fall in an arc, and I realized what it was.

“…A car?”

It had been crushed into a ball, but I could still see it clearly.

The crumpled hood. The twisted scrap metal.

The shower of glass spilling from it as it hurtled toward us.

And exactly where it was going to land.

Whoooooosh!

Oh, shit.

Why here of all places?

Chapter 207

Whoooosh.

An unidentified black sphere plummeted with a terrifying roar, tearing through the air.

As its shadow fell across the taxi, the driver, Mr. Park, knew he was going to die.

So this is how it ends.

The faces of his daughter, who had started high school that year, and his beloved wife flashed before his eyes. They had planned to go out for seolleongtang after work. Who knew that would be foreshadowing?[1084]

And today wasn't even lucky.

He didn't wonder what the thing was. Finding out wouldn't change the fact that he was about to die.

All he could do was sit frozen like a statue and stare helplessly as death drew closer by the second.

Whoooom!

It was time to depart for the afterlife.

The sphere's shadow swallowed the driver's seat. Mr. Park squeezed his eyes shut and finally screamed.

"Gaaaaaaaaah!"

Boom! Craaash!

Sheet metal crumpled like paper, and shards of glass flew in every direction. Then, in the next instant—

"Whoa, my eardrums almost burst. You've got quite a set of lungs on you."

"Gaaah… Huh?"

A voice pierced his ears.

Mr. Park stopped screaming and blinked.

"Huh? Huhhh?"

He couldn't tell whether he was dreaming or awake.

He had definitely been sitting in the driver's seat a second ago—no, half a second ago—but now he was sitting on the shoulder of the road roughly five meters[1085] away.

"W-What the hell…"

Mr. Park stared blankly at his taxi, now crushed flat, then looked up.

His savior was standing there—the man who had snatched him from the jaws of death.

[1084] Seolleongtang is a Korean ox-bone soup. The meal alludes to *A Lucky Day*, a Korean short story in which a rickshaw puller buys seolleongtang for his sick wife, only to return home and find her dead.

[1085] Five meters is about 16 ft.

“Y-You’re the passenger?”

The sturdily built young man, Jin Taekyung, did not answer. He was frowning at something in the distance.

“Sir.”

Mr. Park’s heart pounded. He already understood it instinctively. Something terrible was happening, and if he wanted to survive, he had to do exactly as this Hunter said.

“Run back the way we came. Don’t look back. Just keep running.”

“Y-Yes, sir!”

“And don’t forget to warn everyone else.”

“W-Warn them about what?”

Jin Taekyung pointed ahead.

Bright morning sunlight poured from the clear sky, but darkness was gathering where his finger pointed.

He spoke calmly to Mr. Park, whose mouth hung open in shock.

“A Gate has opened.”

At that moment, a bloodcurdling roar erupted from the far end of the road.

—Gwooooooar!

The monster’s roar was more effective than any loudspeaker.

The moment people realized what was happening, panic swept through them. They abandoned their cars and ran.

“A Gate! A Gate has appeared!”

“Run!”

“Seokjun! Honey!”

The gridlocked road descended into chaos in an instant.

Piercing screams and frantic shouts rang out from every direction.

I avoided the people sprinting back the way they had come and raced forward across the roofs of the cars. A System notification rang in my ears.

Ding.

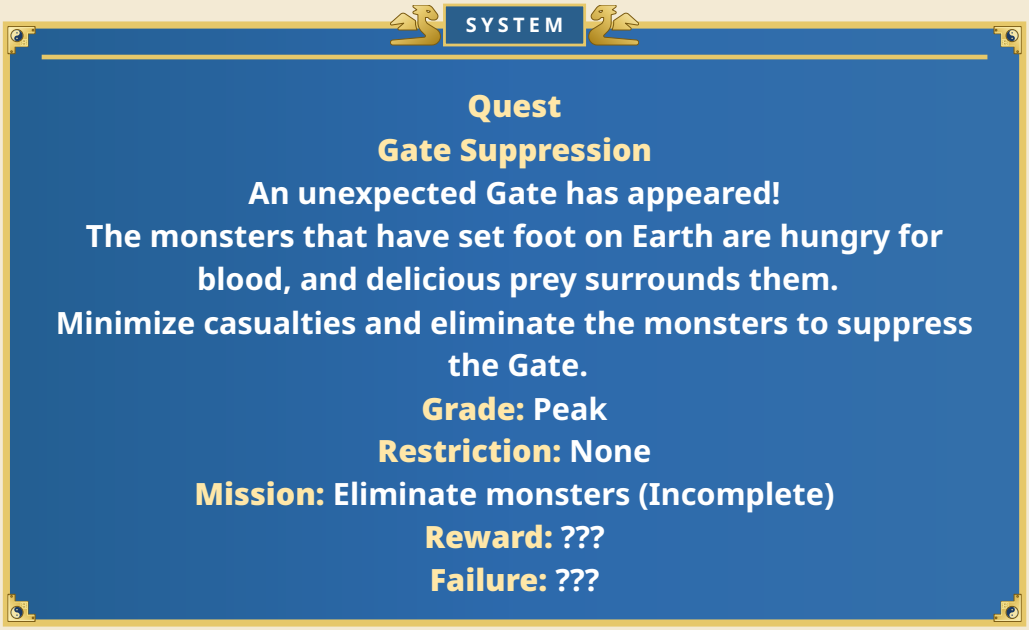
SYSTEM

A sudden Quest, Gate Suppression, has been created.
You cannot refuse the Quest.
The Quest has been forcibly accepted!

Now it isn’t even giving me a choice.

Couldn’t it at least ask first?

I clicked my tongue and opened the Quest window. A translucent holographic panel popped into the air.



This was a goddamn disaster.

Of all places, a Gate had appeared on a road jammed with morning commuters—not at sea or in the mountains.

Worse, the monsters weren’t small fry like goblins or Orcs.

—Gwooooooooar!

Boom! Krrr-boom!

They were larger than cargo trucks, with fangs bigger and sharper than industrial saw blades. Every swing of their dark iron clubs smashed concrete and cars to pieces.

In both strength and appearance, they were monsters in every sense of the word.

I never thought I’d run into creatures I’d only seen in monster encyclopedias on my way to work.

I muttered under my breath.

“Ogres…”

They were classified as B-rank monsters, but their strength and destructive instincts went far beyond that.

During the early days of the Great Cataclysm, it had been ogres who served as the vanguard of the monster legions and destroyed countless cities.

That must be why they’re considered top-tier even among B-rank monsters.

And now they had appeared right here.

The Gate had yet to open fully, so there were only five or six of them. Even that was an enormous threat.

I have to stop them before the casualties get any worse.

I wasn't the only one who thought so. Eight hundred meters[1086] ahead, I saw about twenty figures charging toward the ogres as they swung their weapons in every direction.

"Stop them!"

Clang-clang-clang!

Gleaming armor, shields, and all manner of weapons.

They were Hunters.

B-rank Hunter Hwang Cheol Soo broke out in a cold sweat.

A Gate… appeared?

What were the odds of a Gate appearing? He didn't know the exact figure, but he had heard they were lower than the odds of most natural disasters.

After the death of Demon King Asmodeus brought the Great Cataclysm to an end, the dozens of Gates that had once formed around the world each day became far less frequent. Leading scholars rushed to publish papers about the change.

Humanity's Victory: The End of Gates.

The Connection Between Demon King Asmodeus and the Gates.

Complete Peace Within Ten Years.

But they had all been wrong.

Gates had once appeared only once or twice every year or two, yet this was already the fourth to form in the country this year.

Worse, that fourth Gate had opened at the tollgate Hwang Cheol Soo was responsible for.

And it's a B-rank Gate.

That alone was horrifying enough, but the creatures emerging from it were ogres, classified as top-tier even among B-rank monsters.

Boom! Thud-thud-thud!

"Guh!"

"Healer!"

"Archers, keep firing! Tanks, draw their attention!"

Thud-thud-thud!

The tollgate team—two B-rank Hunters and fifteen C-rank Hunters—was being driven back helplessly.

After only two or three blows from an ogre's iron club, tower shields shattered and the tanks went flying one after another.

[1086] Eight hundred meters is about 0.5 mi.

What am I looking at?

Hwang Cheol Soo was only thirty.

He possessed neither combat instincts nor leadership ability. He was merely a public-service Hunter whose high rank had secured him a comfortable job and a generous pension.

What do I do? How am I supposed to handle this…?

As Hwang Cheol Soo stood frozen like a plaster statue, the assistant team leader shouted at him.

“Team Leader! Pull yourself together! We have to hold out until support arrives, no matter what it takes!”

“Y-Yeah. Right. We only have to last five more minutes.”

“We can take them once the special forces regiment and the nearby Hunters arrive. So—”

Wham! Boom!

Hwang Cheol Soo stared blankly as the assistant team leader was hurled into a refrigerated truck. A huge chunk of concrete had flown out of nowhere and struck him.

“Healer!”

The instant Hwang Cheol Soo shouted, he realized something.

The team had only two healers, and the assistant team leader had been the last one still standing.

Of the seventeen team members, Hwang Cheol Soo included, fewer than half remained on their feet.

“W-What the hell…”

Only one minute had passed since the battle began.

But the outcome had already been decided.

The gap between top-tier B-rank monsters and Hunters who had been lulled into peace while playing mobile games at a tollgate was simply overwhelming.

And their ordeal wasn’t over yet.

“Team Leader!”

“The Gate! Look at the Gate!”

Grkkk, grkkk—

At the team members’ shouts, the rift in the air began to widen.

Magical power churned within the pitch-black darkness as it spewed out enormous bodies.

—Gwoooooar!

—Kraaaagh!

Boom! Boom! Boom!

The ogres landed with savage bellows, and groans of despair rose from all around.

“Fuck…”

“A-Ah…”

The Hunters had been overwhelmingly outmatched even with nearly three times the numbers.

Now that the number of ogres had risen to ten, despair settled heavily over them.

“T-Team Leader…”

“W-What do we do now?”

“…”

Hwang Cheol Soo swallowed dryly.

The difference in strength was overwhelming. The outcome was no longer in question.

Only one thought filled his mind.

Can I survive?

He wasn’t the only one wondering that. Everyone there shared the same question.

And they were waiting for their commander to give them the answer they wanted.

“Team Leader!”

“I-I…”

Before he could finish speaking, Hwang Cheol Soo’s feet were already edging backward.

He had once sworn to become humanity’s shield and protect the people from the threat of monsters.

But he had no intention of dying like a dog here.

Even with reinforcements, we can’t kill those things.

That left only one option.

“B-Based on the commander’s judgment, we’ll make a strategic retreat…”

The moment Hwang Cheol Soo began speaking in a trembling voice—

Whoooooosh! Boom!

A streak of light shot past.

It flew over the heads of the Hunters slowly backing away, punched straight through its target, and blew it apart.

Splash.

What fell from the air in scattered droplets wasn’t rain, but blood. Chunks of rotten-smelling flesh followed, pelting down like hail.

“…Huh?”

Boom.

As someone let out a dazed murmur, the ogre’s enormous body toppled like a rotten old tree.

—Gwo?

“What the…?”

Humans and monsters alike stared blankly at the surreal sight.

Then—

“Whoa. What’s with that firepower?”

The cheerful voice was completely out of place.

Hwang Cheol Soo whirled around to find its owner, and goose bumps ran down his skin.

“Gasp.”

He hadn’t sensed the slightest trace of the newcomer’s presence. Even now, while staring directly at him, he still couldn’t.

But the figure standing tall atop a tour bus was neither a ghost nor a monster.

His eyes curved like half-moons between his roughly tousled black-brown hair.

“Hello.”

“W-Who are you?”

“Just someone on his way to work.”

“P-Pardon?”

“Uh, may I skip the formalities and get straight to the point?”

That was exactly what Hwang Cheol Soo wanted. The ogres had already recovered from their brief confusion and were approaching, dragging their iron clubs across the ground.

The Hunters nodded frantically. The young man, Jin Taekyung, grinned.

“If you’re not going to fight, all of you go stay tucked away in a corner.”

“…”

“Oh, and if I catch you stealing EXP, you’re dead.”

EXP? Stealing?

Before they could even figure out what he meant, the spear in Jin Taekyung’s hand turned into light and shot forward.

Whooooooosh!

Shriiiing! Crunch!

The spearhead punched through a thick jaw.

It tore through hide, flesh, tongue, and palate in succession before jutting out through the top of the ogre’s skull.

Iron clubs came hurtling in from both sides.

Whoooosh!

The air split with a terrifying shriek.

But I was already gone.

I slipped in close against one ogre's body, pulled a dagger from my Inventory, and drove it precisely into its Huiyin Acupoint.[1087]

Stab!

—Gwooooooooooooooooar!

"Congratulations on opening your Conception Vessel."

There was a world of difference between having a pathway forced open and opening one up.

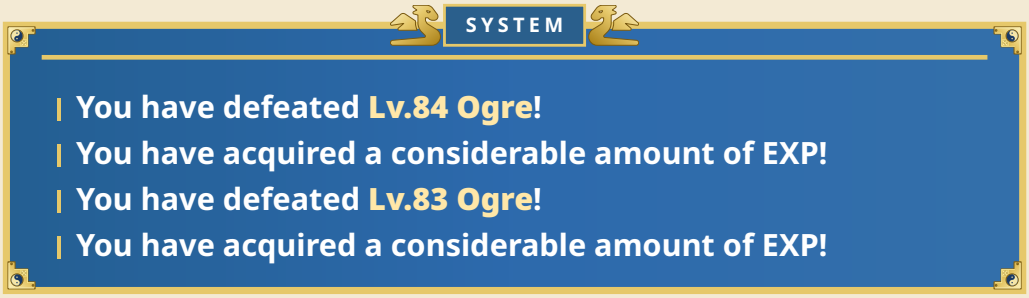
The ogre dropped to its knees with a howl that came from the depths of its soul.

Before it had time to feel any more pain, I slashed its throat with the dagger.

Squelch!

Monster blood and screams filled the air, while a succession of sweet sounds tickled my ears.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Buuuuurp.

Man, I'm stuffed.

[1087] The Huiyin Acupoint is located in the perineum, between the genitals and anus. It is the starting point of the Conception Vessel in traditional acupuncture.

Chapter 208

Ranging unchecked in every direction.

That was me now. Wherever I looked, whatever came within reach, I cut, stabbed, and smashed my way through it. Every flash of my spearhead sent blood spraying and split flesh from bone.

I moved freely among the enormous ogres with nothing to stop me.

Srrk! Krrrunch!

—Gwooooooar!

With a death rattle, the three-meter-tall[1088] hulk dropped to its knees.

The Gate continued spewing out ogres, but they posed no problem for me. When two came out, I killed three. When three came out, I killed four.

This is easy. Almost ridiculously so.

The last time I had assigned points was during my duel with Chulwoo.

But opening my Conception and Governor Vessels had pushed my control and explosive power over my internal energy—as well as my senses—to an entirely new level.

Even when the ogres' iron clubs came crashing down from every direction with tremendous force, they looked unbelievably slow.

To me, the ogres were nothing but idiots who had no idea how to use their own strength.

Whoooosh! Thud!

—Grrrgh…

Another ogre—I'd lost count by now—dropped to its knees with a wet, blood-choked rattle.

Its furry hand reached for the spearhead piercing straight through its Adam's apple, then went limp and fell away.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv.85 Ogre!
You have acquired a considerable amount of EXP!
Level Up!

"Oh."

I'd leveled up already.

Clearing them out by myself was raking in EXP at an insane rate.

[1088] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

Is it because every last one of these bastards is higher-level than me?

My current Level was somewhere in the mid-to-high seventies, putting the ogres anywhere from five to ten Levels above me.

And since I was slicing through them like slabs of pork shoulder at a butcher shop, it was only natural that my Level would rise quickly.

The EXP was far more generous than I'd expected.

No, wait.

A thought flashed through my mind.

Eyes shining, I stared at the Gate as it churned and spat out another ogre.

This place was practically…

The hottest restaurant in town.

The Gate kept spitting out EXP—or rather, monsters—and I kept killing them. If that cycle continued…

So this is where the conveyor-belt sushi place was hiding.

The EXP from the ogres was sweeter than tuna belly.

My mouth curled into a grin at the thought of chewing up every ogre that came out and digesting them into points.

That was when it happened.

Vroooom. Rat-a-tat-tat-tat!

—Hold! Hold!

—Drop!

Three or four combat helicopters flew in on a blast of wind and circled overhead. Around twenty Hunters dropped from them like bolts of lightning.

Shu-shu-shu-shu!

They were falling from a height of more than twenty meters.[1089] From that high up, even Hunters equipped with magical Equipment were bound to strain their knees on landing.

But these newcomers weren't the incompetent amateurs who had been here before I arrived.

"Feather Fall."

At the mage's incantation, a ripple of mana passed through the air.

The bodies plunging rapidly toward the ground began to slow. The ogres about to swing their iron clubs hesitated when their timing was thrown off, and then the second spell activated.

"Grease!"

—Gwo?

Boom! Crash!

[1089] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

The four remaining ogres lost their balance. Some staggered, while others collapsed to the ground.

"Now!"

At the shout, the spell slowing the Hunters' descent was released, and the melee fighters shot forward like streaks of light.

The ogres let out low growls as they sensed their imminent deaths.

That was when—

Clang! Clang-clang!

"…Huh?"

The Hunters who had been about to plunge their weapons into the ogres' chests stared at me in disbelief.

What the hell did this bastard just do?

Is he insane?

That was exactly what their faces said.

I had knocked aside every one of their attacks with a single swing. In my most reasonable voice, I said, "Come on. Let's show a little professional courtesy."

"…"

These bastards were trying to steal mobs I already had dead to rights.

"That really happened?"

At the captain's question, the Hunter Team Leader nodded.

"Yes. I've been on the support team for two years, and I've never seen anyone like him."

"He sounds interesting."

"Interesting? He's a complete psycho."

"Perhaps."

The captain slowly surveyed the area.

The tollgate had collapsed so completely that its original shape was unrecognizable, and monster blood lay splattered across the half-destroyed road.

There were overturned and wrecked cars as well, but not many.

"How many casualties?"

Soldiers and Hunters had different statuses, but both were registered with the government as members of military support teams.

The Hunter Team Leader promptly answered his superior's question.

"So far, four dead and five severely injured. We'll know more once we finish checking."

"Four dead and five severely injured."

The captain calmly repeated the figures, then continued.

“This is already the second Gate occurrence today.”

“Tell me about it. An F-rank Gate erupted near Yangju City about an hour ago. I don’t know if something serious is going on.”

The captain clicked his tongue.

“Hey, Team Leader Jeong.”

“Yes, sir.”

“An F-rank Gate that appeared in the town center, or a B-rank Gate that appeared in the middle of a road packed with commuters. Which one looks more serious?”

“Well…”

“But the F-rank Gate caused more casualties. Ten dead and more than twenty severely injured.”

“What? That can’t be right. The breaking news said…”

“They downplayed it. Covered it up. You’ve been doing this for two years. You should know how things work around here by now.”

The captain let out a deep sigh.

“As far as we’re concerned, a hundred bows wouldn’t be enough to thank him. He’s a civilian hero who single-handedly prevented a catastrophe.”

“That’s true. He does seem a little crazy, though.”

“Team Leader Jeong.”

“Ah, no, that’s not what I meant. I mean he’s insanely strong *and* crazy. He killed more than ten ogres by himself, so he must be an A-rank Hunter or something.”

“Either way, watch what you say. There are plenty of ears around.”

“They’re all our people. What ears could there be—ah.”

Team Leader Jeong followed the captain’s gaze and immediately scowled.

A skinny, middle-aged man carrying an expensive camera was approaching with an excited spring in his step.

“Captain Yoo! Team Leader Jeong! Where have you two been hiding? I’ve been looking everywhere.”

The Hunter Team Leader replied with open displeasure.

“Hiding from you, Reporter Kim.”

“Oh, come on. Why are you so prickly today, Team Leader Jeong? I’m part of the support team too.”

“You’re only part of the team at times like this, huh? The rest of the time, you’re a military correspondent. You’re usually drowning in a hangover, and now you’re beside yourself just because you landed a scoop.”

The reporter flinched, and the captain stepped in.

"That's enough. And Reporter Kim, please be more mindful in the future. This is an accident scene. Running around by yourself in high spirits because you found a scoop doesn't look good."

"…Ahem. I'll be more careful from now on."

Even as he answered, anticipation gleamed in the reporter's eyes.

A Gate occurrence was nothing short of a natural disaster. In some ways, it was even worse.

If a typhoon was going to strike the Korean Peninsula, people could at least predict when and how it would arrive and which areas might be damaged. There was no predicting where or when a Gate would form.

Two Gates in one day was already unprecedented, and one of them was even B-rank.

A tollgate security team helplessly overrun, followed by the heroic arrival of an unknown Hunter who prevented a rush-hour catastrophe!

It was a great story.

The reporter had already sketched the whole article out in his head, and he was itching to get started.

"So where's our hero? He's an A-rank Hunter, right? What's his name? A fresh new face would sell better for a story like this."

"A new face? Give me a break."

The Hunter Team Leader pointed behind the reporter.

"He's over there. Your new face."

"Where? I don't see him."

No matter how much he looked around, there was no sign of a hero clad in gleaming armor.

All he could see were military personnel busily cleaning up the accident scene.

The reporter's eyes swept across the area before suddenly stopping.

"There, Team Leader Jeong. Is that him? In front of the ogre corpse…"

"The man in the sweatpants? Yes, that's him."

Swish. Srrk, srrk.

Squatting as if he were making a huge batch of kimchi,[1090] the young man deftly separated the fat, meat, and hide from the corpse. The reporter muttered,

"…Now *that's* a new face."

"Fresh, right? Isn't that the picture you wanted?"

"The ogre meat certainly looks fresh."

"He's been at it for a while. The staff offered to do it for him, but he won't let them touch anything. Says it's all his."

[1090] Making kimchi in large batches, known as *kimjang*, is traditionally a communal household activity in Korea.

Even funnier, his butchering technique was unbelievably good. The two employees assigned to process the corpses kept sneaking glances at his hands and copying his movements.

"Is he really an A-rank Hunter?"

"Who knows? He must be if he can wipe out ogres by himself, but the longer I look at him, the less convinced I am."

"Team Leader Jeong asked him, but he said they could talk once he finished butchering."

The three men exchanged looks filled with equal parts belief and doubt.

That was when—

"Whew. Finished."

The A-rank Hunter, who had cut the notoriously tough ogre meat into pieces like mackerel, straightened his back and stood up.

The reporter took in his sweatpants, baggy at the knees, and his three-striped slides, then muttered,

"Why does a guy who makes that much money live like this?"

Was this some kind of humblebrag?

It was absurd, yet the longer the reporter looked, the more novel the whole thing seemed. After all, nothing mattered more in the media than character.

A down-to-earth A-rank Hunter with a fierce sense of justice. This will make a great story. He's handsome, too, with bold, clean-cut features.

Yes, this was much better than some polished model-student image.

The reporter grinned and raised his camera.

He wanted a natural shot with no staging whatsoever.

That's an ogre for you. Not a single part goes to waste.

I looked over the neatly separated by-products with a satisfied smile.

Ogres were practically symbols of strength, which made them popular among men.

There were plenty of customers, but because ogres were classified among the highest tier of B-rank monsters, the supply was limited.

Good thing I only went for their vital spots.

I was humming as I sorted the by-products when—

Click.

"…Huh?"

I turned toward the mechanical sound that had come out of nowhere.

A middle-aged man repeatedly pressing his camera shutter smiled amiably at me.

"Oh dear, did I startle you?"

What the hell is with this guy?

I stared at him incredulously. "Most people are surprised when someone takes their picture without permission. You expect me to be happy about it?"

"You might be once you're in tomorrow's newspaper."

"The newspaper?"

"Ah, I haven't introduced myself yet. Here, let's start with my business card."

I accepted the military-camouflage business card and read it aloud.

"Military correspondent."

"You know the Capital Defense Command, right? I'm the military correspondent assigned to Support Team 25."

"Ah, yes."

"And the two gentlemen coming up behind me are from the support team as well."

The reporter smiled and gave me a thumbs-up as two men approached from behind him.

One wore a Special Forces uniform and the other wore armor. They were, well, dressed like your stereotypical soldier and Hunter.

"Nice to meet you. I'm Captain Yoo Sijin, Team Leader of Support Team 25."

"Ah, yes."

For some reason, that sounded like a name the sun might regret.[1091]

I tilted my head and exchanged introductions with the two men.

The perfunctory introductions and praise for my heroic deed had barely ended when the military correspondent, who had been staring at me with fervent eyes, spoke up.

"You said you're Hunter Jin Taekyung, correct?"

"Yes. Why?"

"Given the field I cover, I know nearly every A-rank Hunter. But…"

Ah, I had a pretty good idea what he was trying to say.

It was something I would have to deal with sooner or later.

I answered readily, "I'm not A-rank."

"What?"

"And I'm not S-rank either, of course."

"…"

Question marks seemed to appear on all three faces at once. I couldn't help chuckling.

This is fun.

[1091] Captain Yoo Si-jin is the name of the male lead in the Korean drama *Descendants of the Sun*.

After being knocked around this way and that in another world, I hide my strength in reality.

That would make a decent novel title.

When I merely smiled without answering, the reporter spoke in a faltering voice.

“Th-Then perhaps you’re B-rank?”

“No. I’m C-rank.”

“…C-rank? You mean C-rank, not C-cup?”

“Yes.”

What kind of bullshit is C-cup? And why the hell is he looking at my chest?

I ignored their waves of disbelief and continued, “I was on my way to the Guild when a Gate happened to open…”

“Th-Then what?”

I couldn’t answer the reporter’s urgent question.

I had just remembered something I’d momentarily forgotten.

“…By any chance, what time is it?”

Damn it. I’m late.

Chapter 209

Ten in the morning.

Im Kkeokjeong, a D-rank Hunter with the Peace Guild, arrived at work after a blissful vacation and stopped dead, his mouth hanging open.

“Whoa. What is this?”

His reaction was understandable.

Before his vacation—just one week ago—the Guild House had looked like a run-down neighborhood corner store on the verge of collapse.

But now, right before his eyes, stood a sign made of gleaming marble and luxurious lettering.

“Wow. They really went all out on the remodeling.”

As Kkeokjeong admired the exterior, a familiar voice came from somewhere.

“Why are you standing outside instead of coming in?”

Startled, he looked around. But there wasn’t so much as an ordinary security camera or intercom in sight, so he cautiously spoke up.

“Te-Team Leader Choi? Is that you?”

“Yes. It’s me.”

“What is this? How are you talking to me?”

The reply came without a moment’s hesitation, as though he had been waiting for that exact question.

“It’s nothing special. We commissioned Vercheni, a venerable Italian family of artisans, to custom-make it for us. It incorporates message, observation, and alarm magic…”

“Ah, no. You don’t have to explain all that.”

“Oh. Then simply open the mahogany door, which is covered in the hide of a fire-resistant salamander, and come inside…”

“I’m coming in! I said I’m coming in!”

“…Yes.”

Click.

The locked door slid open along with the strangely dejected reply.

The interior of the Guild House had changed just as dramatically as the exterior. Three people were waiting for Kkeokjeong inside.

“Welcome back.”

“Hunter Im.”

“Uncle, you’re here?”

There was Team Leader Choi, the true power behind the Peace Guild; Butler Kim, its nominal Guild Master; and Song Song, the guild’s sole female member.

The three of them were seated around a round table. As they greeted him in turn, Im Kkeokjeong let out a good-natured laugh.

"Maybe it's because it's been a while, but it's good to see you all. Did everyone get plenty of rest over the vacation?"

The moment he finished speaking, the expressions of all three changed strangely.

After a brief silence, Song Song spoke.

"I got some rest. There were so many bugs at home that they kept bothering me, though."

"Bugs?"

"Yes. Didn't you have any bugs at your place, Uncle?"

Kkeokjeong tilted his head.

Come to think of it, his wife had complained about something similar a few times during their vacation.

"Nothing much, just a fly or two. She said they kept coming in no matter how many she caught, so I left them alone, and then they quieted down. They hardly flew around, either."

"Oh, really?"

"Yeah. I've never seen such well-behaved flies."

Song Song shuddered uneasily.

"There were so many of them that I felt too creeped out to shower. It was like the bugs were watching me."

"The bugs? Hahaha! Miss Song, you sure know how to joke around."

"…"

Im Kkeokjeong threw his head back and laughed. He failed to notice the other three exchanging meaningful looks and words he could not hear.

Hunter Im doesn't seem to know.

Looks like he didn't notice.

Wow. How can this guy be so oblivious?

Unlike the other three, who had spent their entire vacation under surveillance by Familiars sent by the Sangdong Guild, Kkeokjeong had enjoyed a truly blissful break without knowing a thing.

It wasn't that he hadn't been watched. He had been watched; he simply didn't know it.

Ignorance truly was bliss.

"Those fucking perverts. If I catch them later, I'm going to rip their balls off."

Song Song's muttering would have sent chills down the spines of the Sangdong Guild's mages if they had heard it.

Kkeokjeong abruptly stopped laughing.

"Huh? What did you just say? Perverts?"

“No. I just said the bugs were disgusting.”

“Is it still bad? I know someone who works in that line of business. Want me to ask them about it?”

Song Song gave a quiet laugh at his genuine concern, then pressed her lips together and pointed at the two people sitting beside her.

“They’re all gone now. Those two took care of it. Especially Butler Kim.”

“Really? Kim hyung[1092]—I mean, Guild Master. I guess you know a thing or two about that kind of work.”

Butler Kim answered with an awkward smile.

“Not really. It just so happens that a junior of mine works in that field.”

“Ah, pest control?”

“…Yes. Something like that.”

In a way, monsters were merely enormous pests, so that wasn’t entirely wrong.

Im Kkeokjeong, who had effectively turned one of Bucheon’s leading Hunter Guilds into Cesco,[1093] continued in all seriousness.

“Your junior must be pretty good at his job.”

“Oh, he is.”

He was so good at beating them down that he was one of the war heroes of the Great Cataclysm.

Of course, to Butler Kim, Sangdong Guild Master Im Chunsoo was merely one of the trainees he had once worked like a dog.

“Let’s leave it at that. More importantly…”

Team Leader Choi had been grimacing for some time as he struggled to hold back his laughter. He quickly changed the subject.

There happened to be one person who made for a much more suitable topic.

“Why isn’t Jin Taekyung here?”

While they had been chatting and laughing, their scheduled start time had long since passed.

Only now realizing Jin Taekyung’s absence, Im Kkeokjeong nervously stroked his beard.

“What’s going on? Taekyung’s never done this before. When it comes to diligence, he’s the best person I know.”

“I’m well aware of that.”

Team Leader Choi nodded.

He had already investigated Taekyung’s past thoroughly. Judging by the several years documented in the report and everything he had personally witnessed since, Taekyung’s diligence and tenacity were genuine.

[1092] *Hyung* is how a man addresses an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[1093] Cesco is a Korean pest-control company.

The raid starts in two hours…

Had something happened?

Team Leader Choi was still considering the possibilities as he picked up his phone when Song Song, who had been quiet for a while, suddenly spoke.

“Taurus—I mean, Jin Taekyung.”

“…”

“He’s right there.”

Her pale, slender finger pointed over Team Leader Choi’s shoulder.

The next moment, the guild members naturally turned in the direction she indicated, and their mouths fell open.

A familiar face filled the eighty-inch television screen mounted on the wall of the Guild House.

“…Huh.”

“Taekyung! Isn’t that Taekyung?”

“I-I believe that is indeed Hunter Jin Taekyung.”

Even the perpetually composed Butler Kim was so flustered that he stammered.

By then, however, the guild members’ attention had already been seized by the caption beneath Taekyung’s face.

Jin Taekyung *(Wonmi-gu, Bucheon. C-rank Hunter)*

Live: Tollgate Hero

“Tollgate Hero? What’s that supposed to mean? Why can’t we hear anything?”

“It’s muted! The TV’s on mute! Turn the sound on, quick!”

Only after someone hurriedly fiddled with the television did the blocked sound begin to spill out.

Fwoosh-fwoosh-fwoosh-fwoosh! Rat-a-tat-a-tat!

Along with some incomprehensible noise, Jin Taekyung’s voice continued.

“…And that’s how it happened.”

“I see. Then could you give us a few final words about how you feel?”

“Uh, first of all, I love my family very much, and I’m incredibly grateful to all the members of the Peace Guild. And to the person I like…”

“Yes! I see.”

“W-Wait a second.”

“That’s all the time we have. Viewers, this has been our interview with Jin Taekyung, the Tollgate Hero!”

After one last shot of the reporter’s beaming face, the screen switched to a cosmetics commercial.

Im Kkeokjeong shouted, “What the hell was that? I couldn’t hear anything!”

“Hold on. I’ll search for it right now. Tollgate Hero, Tollgate Hero… Holy crap.”

“Song-i. What is it?”

Song Song had frozen, her eyes wide. Without a word, she held out her phone.

The main page of the web portal was displayed on the screen. The three syllables of Jin Taekyung’s name were plastered across it.

“Jin Taekyung is number one on the real-time search rankings.”

The Guild House fell silent as though someone had dumped ice water over everyone inside.

No one knew what to say about this completely unexpected turn of events.

Then—

Fwoosh-fwoosh-fwoosh-fwoosh! Rat-a-tat-a-tat!

“Whoa.”

“No way.”

It was the same sound they had heard during Jin Taekyung’s interview only a few dozen seconds earlier.

Everyone whipped around to look at the television, only to sigh when they saw the cosmetics commercial was still playing.

But only for a moment.

“Wait. Then why can we still hear it?”

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim were the first to realize where the noise was coming from. They shouted together.

“Outside!”

“It’s outside! It isn’t the television!”

Crash!

The words had barely left their mouths when everyone sprang to their feet.

“Whoa, what is this?”

“Is this the right place?”

“Yeah, this is the Peace Guild. I heard they remodeled, but it looks incredible.”

“Would it be possible to interview the other guild members as well?”

“No. You cut my interview short earlier.”

“Hunter, about earlier…”

The speaker spell relayed the conversation with perfect clarity.

With the other guild members watching, Team Leader Choi steadied his breathing and brought the message-magic Equipment to his mouth.

“Jin Taekyung. It’s me.”

“Whoa, what the hell? Sound Transmission? Is that you, Team Leader Choi?”

“Yes.”

“What was that? How did you do it?”

Team Leader Choi opened his mouth without hesitation.

It was an instinct etched deep into his bones.

“It’s nothing special. We commissioned Vercheni, a venerable Italian family of artisans, to custom-make it for us…”

Kkeokjeong muttered a string of vicious curses under his breath.

I went to sleep and woke up a star.

I had never imagined I would experience that saying for real in my lifetime.

Especially not in real time like this.

“Hey, registered sibling.[1094] I just saw something I can’t believe.”

“Registered sibling? You want to die?”

“No, that’s not the point right now.”

Hayeon’s voice over the phone was filled with shock and disbelief.

“Oppa,[1095] your name is on Naver’s real-time search rankings…”

I could easily guess what she was about to say.

I had already received dozens of calls with similar questions over the past few hours.

I cut Hayeon off before she could continue.

“Number one on the real-time search rankings. Yeah, that’s me. It really is.”

“…Seriously? The Seoul Outer Ring Expressway Tollgate Hero? That’s you?”

“Don’t call me that. I’m dying of embarrassment.”

“Wow. I guess it really is you. The second I tapped your name, your profile picture popped up under ‘Person in the News.‘ Even after seeing it, I still thought there was no way.”

Even I hadn’t expected it to cause such a huge stir.

Only a few hours had passed, but searching my name online already brought up dozens of clickbait articles.

“What on earth happened? I read the articles, and it sounded insane. You’re not hurt, are you?”

“I didn’t even get a scratch, and it’d take too long to tell you the whole story. What about Mom? Has she heard the news about me?”

“Not yet. But if she finds out you fought monsters like that, she’ll faint.”

Hayeon wasn’t exaggerating.

What kind of creature was an ogre?

[1094] “Registered sibling” is a joking way to refer to a sibling as someone connected by the family register, rather than by affection.

[1095] *Oppa* is how a woman addresses an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.

Even someone who knew nothing about monsters could search a few times and learn that they were every bit as powerful as their grotesque appearance suggested.

I could already picture how Mom would react when she heard her son had fought such monsters.

“Damn. You’re right.”

“Ugh, I don’t even know anymore. Get home before everything blows up and at least show her your face.”

“Okay. I’ll stop by after the interview.”

“Interview? Are you doing one right now?”

“Yeah.”

“Where? For a women’s magazine or something?”

“The KPS Nine O’Clock News Desk. I’m waiting for my turn.”

“…Holy crap.”

Just as I was about to answer Hayeon, a television-station producer weighed down with Equipment urgently waved at me.

“This is live, so I have to go. See you at home later.”

“Uh-huh? O-Okay…”

I hung up and headed toward a news studio I had only ever seen on television.

Recording Equipment filled the place, and the station staff were all watching me. My mouth went dry, and my legs began to shake.

I’d rather fight a hundred ogres.

Each second felt like an eternity, but at last, the signal I had been waiting for came.

“We’re going live. Stand by… cue!”

Chapter 210

Sometimes, a carelessly tossed spark can grow into a massive blaze.

A day passed, then two, then three… and after about a week, that tiny spark had spread into a forest fire—with me standing at its center.

[Korea Daily] The Rise of an F-Rank Hunter. “I Just Followed the Manual.”

[Goryeo Daily] The Birth of a New Hero. “Watch Out, S-Rank Hunters!”

[Happy Thoughts] Man in His Twenties Prevents Major Disaster. “I Only Did What Anyone Should Have Done.”

[Current Hot Topic] Two Gates Open in a Single Day… An Unprecedented Crisis, and a Fierce Clash Between the Ruling and Opposition Parties Over National Defense and Security

[Parliament’s Words of the Day] Freedom Patriot Party Chairman’s Outrageous Remark Draws Attention: “Jin Taekyung Has Thick Arms, So He’s Clearly Conservative. Conservatives Saved the Country.”

Daily newspapers, weekly papers, current-affairs magazines, lifestyle magazines, and more.

The newspapers and magazines piled high on the table all had one thing in common: my face and name were plastered across them.

Even looking at them was enough to make me feel overwhelmed by the sheer volume.

Why are there so many?

How many interviews had I given over the past week?

Every media outlet hungry for an exclusive had seized the opportunity and unleashed a flood of articles.

Reporters had staked out the Guild House and my home, while my personal information, past activities, and photographs circulated across the internet.

Jesus. These people are fucking insane.

I had thought I was somewhat used to fame after becoming fairly well-known in Murim, but compared to this, that had been nothing.

Korea had long been an internet powerhouse, and even those respectable, gray-haired people in their fifties had histories as keyboard warriors.

The saying that you could meet the entire country just by visiting a few major online communities wasn’t baseless nonsense.

“Why is everyone so interested in other people’s business?”

[1096] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

[1097] *Bibimbap* is a Korean dish of rice mixed with vegetables and other toppings, often served with chili paste.

At my mutter, Jinho hyung[1096] shrugged while eating bibimbap[1097] from a large metal bowl.

"It's a good thing. You're famous for doing something good."

"I don't know about that. There are all kinds of lunatics out there."

"Ah, right. What happened with your family…"

Jinho quietly shut his mouth when he saw my expression. I hadn't looked in a mirror, but I was sure I looked downright murderous.

Of all the people they could've messed with, they went after my family?

The world really was a big place, and it was full of lunatics.

After I appeared on the KPS Nine O'Clock News, the public response exploded, and reporters hungry for a fresh scoop combed through everything connected to me with a fine-tooth comb.

The problem was that my family's personal information had been exposed in the process.

"You know Hayeon called a few days ago, right? Reporters kept following her whenever she went out, so she ordered delivery—and the delivery guy turned out to be a reporter in disguise."

"Yeah, that bastard really was a hack. I'd heard stories about reporters like that, but I never imagined they'd actually go that far."

"Some of them even hired Familiar mages."

If that wasn't hack journalism and paparazzi behavior, I didn't know what was.

I saw red when I first heard about it, but before I could personally go after the reporter and the media outlet, netizens rose up like wildfire.

Several massive online communities, each claiming more than a million registered members, were still blazing away with hack reporters as their firewood.

> ㄴ **Top Comment:** LOL, these fucking hack reporters are crossing the line again. How many people survived because of Taekyung the Lord,[1098] and they're pulling this shit? I'm embarrassed for them.
>
> ㄴ They would've done the same thing even if their own families had been there. They're just fucking crazy.
>
> ㄴ What company is it? Post the article link.
>
> ㄴ Hailey News. Reporter B.H.Y. The original's been deleted, but it's already too late, LOL.
>
> ㄴ Let's turn it into Hell News.
>
> ㄴ It already is. The site's been shut down.

[1098] "Taekyung the Lord" uses an online nickname convention that playfully elevates someone to an admired figure.

> ㄴ **Top Comment:** I heard another media outlet used wiretapping magic and even hired a Familiar mage. What happened to them?
>
> ㄴ Everyone involved is having a reunion in the holding cells. Their lives are probably over.
>
> ㄴ The commenter above doesn't know Hell Joseon.[1099] The ones who gave the orders will get suspended sentences at worst, LOL.
>
> ㄴ Nope. A national petition went up about it, and it passed three million signatures yesterday. The Blue House is supposedly preparing legislation. Looks like they're going to overhaul the whole system this time.
>
> ㄴ We'll have to wait and see, but I really hope they do.
>
> ㄴ They'll probably clean house while they're at it. Blinded by their hunger for an exclusive, they messed with someone they never should have touched.
>
> ㄴ Me. A man in his twenties. Everyone my age. Loves Jin Taekyung.

The response left me more bewildered than anything else. I was happy, but it also felt like a burden.

I really only did what anyone should have done.

It had been an accident no one could have predicted.

The news kept calling me a hero who had prevented a major disaster, but every now and then, I found myself wondering whether there might have been one fewer casualty if I had been just a little faster.

"What's with that expression?"

"Huh? Nothing."

"Someone with nothing wrong doesn't pick at his food like that."

"I've already eaten three bowls."

"You normally eat at least five."

"…That's true."

"Hey, Taekyung. I'm not really qualified to give you advice, but let me say one thing."

It had been a while since I'd heard Jinho sound so serious. He set down his spoon, still smeared with red pepper paste, and continued slowly.

"Don't try to be a hero."

"…"

"You're not a god. How can you save everyone? Even gods can't do that."

He was right.

[1099] "Hell Joseon" is an online term criticizing the harshness and unfairness of life in Korea.

I wasn't denying the existence or power of a god, but that didn't mean I could reconcile myself to it, either.

The only things I knew for certain were that hundreds of millions of people had died during the Great Cataclysm, that my father had died in an accident, and that my family had lived a poor, desperate life.

"What was your dream again?"

"To let my family live without envying anyone else. To protect the people I care about."

"Sum it up in one word."

A quiet laugh escaped me.

Instead of *landlord*, the word I'd parroted day in and day out, something unexpected came to mind.

The greatest under heaven… no, the greatest of all time?

I briefly lost myself in thought, then hurriedly answered when I saw Jinho's puzzled expression.

"Hmm. A strong Hunter landlord?"

"Exactly. That's enough. You've practically achieved your dream already, so don't torment yourself with pointless greed and guilt."

"Pointless greed…"

"Let me ask you one thing. Taekyung, did you fight those monsters because you wanted all this?"

"Absolutely not."

"Then that's enough."

Jinho grinned and picked up his spoon again.

"Just enjoy it. Think of it as a reward for all the hardship you've endured and the good you've done. Wouldn't that make things easier?"

A reward.

I had already received plenty of rewards through the System, but the reward Jinho was talking about meant something completely different.

It wasn't something material or some kind of power. It was an emotional reward.

He was telling me to find some contentment and room to breathe.

Contentment and room to breathe.

The words felt unfamiliar as I repeated them silently.

Back when I was an F-rank Hunter, I fought monsters for money. Now, I was working even harder to become stronger.

The more I thought about it, the more I realized what a greedy bastard I was.

"Hyung.[1100]"

[1100] *Hyung* is how a Korean man addresses an older brother or an older male friend.

“Yeah? What is it?”

“Nothing. Just… thanks.”

Jinho froze with a heaping spoonful of bibimbap[1101] halfway to his mouth.

“Really?”

“I mean it.”

“Then lend me a hundred thousand won.[1102]”

“Don’t start talking about money just because things got awkward.”

“I mean it, too.”

“…”

What the hell was with this guy?

As I stared at him in disbelief, the phone on the table buzzed, and a text message appeared.

> **Team Leader Choi**
>
> **Team Leader Choi**
>
> I’ve arrived. Come down to the underground parking garage right away.

Just as his message said, Team Leader Choi was waiting for me in the underground parking garage.

The problem was that he wasn’t alone.

“I’m from Oh My God News! Could you say a few words about the current situation?”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, I’m Reporter Hong from Housewives’ Daily. You were voted the number-one ideal man among married women in their forties this week…”

“This is *Vivid Current-Affairs Talk*! What do you think about the comment in Parliament regarding the size of your arms?”

“Where are you going right now? What did you eat?”

More than twenty people thrust cameras and microphones at me. It was utter chaos.

While I let out a deep sigh, Team Leader Choi calmly pushed back the enemy forces.

“Please step aside.”

“Just a moment. It’ll only take a second.”

[1101] *Bibimbap* is a Korean dish of rice mixed with vegetables and other toppings, often served with chili paste.

[1102] One hundred thousand Korean won is about $71 or €65 at the project rates.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung is a member of the Peace Guild. Please submit interview requests through the Guild’s official website.”

When had they even made an official website?

They had posted a massive recruitment notice for new Guild members not long ago, too. It seemed they intended to make the most of this opportunity.

But despite Team Leader Choi’s efforts to stop them, the reporters clung to us stubbornly. Apparently, not getting a single interview over the past few days had eaten away at them.

“You’re the Team Leader of the Peace Guild, right? We weren’t asking you, so move!”

“Yeah, get out of the way! Your website is garbage, too. How long are we supposed to wait after submitting an inquiry before we get an interview?”

“It’s just one word. Why are you acting so precious?”

“Are you looking down on us because we’re a tiny second-rate media outlet?”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung is my team member, and I am currently the Guild’s spokesperson, so I have every right to intervene. The website is functioning normally, I have never played hard to get, and I ignored you because you failed to follow the proper procedure.”

Team Leader Choi answered without so much as blinking as he smoothly pushed the reporters and cameramen aside.

He looked slender, but an incredible amount of strength was packed into that body. He was only using one arm, yet the people blocking our path were pushed back one after another.

“Whoa!”

“Hey, he’s using force now?”

“A Hunter! The Hunter is beating people up!”

Go on, make a whole fucking scene…

I swallowed the words that had risen to my throat.

Just by looking at them, I could tell the reporters in front of us were low quality.

Team Leader Choi had arranged dozens of interviews over the past week as the Guild’s spokesperson. If he was filtering these people out, it didn’t take a taste test to tell whether they were soybean paste or shit.

Why are their questions such garbage in the first place?

They weren’t worth answering. Anything I said would obviously be twisted maliciously before publication.

“We’re coming through.”

Team Leader Choi ignored them and continued clearing a path.

“Whoops!”

Crack!

A camera slipped from someone’s hand, struck the parking-garage floor, and shattered.

The problem was that the entire sequence felt blatantly deliberate.

“My camera! Oh, no!”

His voice was full of anguish, but his eyes gleamed as if he had finally caught us.

Team Leader Choi stared at the cameraman’s terrible acting, then bent down and reached for the broken device.

The cameraman irritably slapped his arm away.

“Don’t touch it! Everything you did was recorded, so you’d better be ready—”

Smack! Crack.

Everyone’s eyes dropped to the floor.

The wristwatch that had fallen from Team Leader Choi’s wrist rolled across the parking-garage floor.

More than ten watch hands. Jewels set densely across its surface. And a face cracked like a spiderweb.

“…”

“…”

Gulp.

The sound of the cameraman swallowing echoed through the parking garage.

Then Team Leader Choi’s quiet voice pierced everyone’s ears.

“The Universe-302, the final masterpiece personally crafted in his later years by Peter Philip, Switzerland’s greatest watchmaker. How tragic that this beautiful pinnacle of automatic mechanical watchmaking, which survived even the Great Cataclysm, should be destroyed so senselessly.”

“…”

Team Leader Choi picked up the watch—Universe, School Bus, or whatever it was—with sorrowful eyes and delivered the final blow.

“I’m suing you.”

At Choi Moses’s miracle, the crowd parted in two.

Vroom.

The luxury sedan glided smoothly over the asphalt.

Team Leader Choi glanced at the rearview mirror and spoke.

“They aren’t following us anymore.”

“…I wouldn’t follow us, either. How much is that watch worth?”

“More than you can imagine. Assuming it’s genuine, of course.”

“Oh, it’s an imitation? No wonder. I thought it was strange that you’d throw away such a valuable luxury watch so easily.”

“You noticed?”

“It would’ve been even stranger if a wristwatch came loose that easily.”

“I only scared them a little. I wore it in case something like this happened. It was a good choice.”

Wasn’t this guy basically Zhuge Liang?[1103]

As I admired Team Leader Choi’s clever trick, something suddenly darted in front of the sedan just as we were leaving the officetel[1104] neighborhood.

“Team Leader Choi!”

Screeeeeech!

Team Leader Choi hit the brakes half a beat before I shouted. Staring through the windshield at the person in front of us, he muttered,

“He doesn’t look like a reporter.”

I agreed.

An ordinary person could not wear such a relaxed smile in a situation like this.

And…

Even without activating Qi Sense, I could feel the considerable energy coiled within the man smiling at us.

A Hunter. A pretty high-level one, too.

The uninvited guest, a man in his early thirties wearing a suit, tapped on the window.

“Let’s talk.”

[1103] Zhuge Liang was a Chinese statesman and strategist renowned for his cleverness.

[1104] An *officetel* is a Korean building containing units used as offices or residences.

Chapter 211

I stared at the man who had suddenly stepped in front of the car.

He's definitely a Hunter, but…

The reason I found myself thinking that despite sensing his extraordinary energy was his flashy appearance.

From his intricately patterned semi-formal suit to the designer labels covering him from head to toe, everything about him screamed luxury.

Then there was his smooth, taut, blemish-free skin and teeth so white they looked almost unnatural.

No matter how I looked at him, he seemed more like a celebrity than a Hunter.

Maybe that was why he looked strangely familiar.

He's even more over the top than Team Leader Choi.

They both liked luxury brands, but the man in front of us took it a little too far.

The huge sunglasses he was wearing on such a gloomy day certainly didn't help.

"Can't you hear me? Is this thing under a noise spell or something?"

At the man's mutter, Team Leader Choi lowered the window.

"What can I do for you?"

"Oh, you can hear me. Then why didn't you answer?"

"We're short on time. If you have nothing else to say, please step aside."

"You must be pretty busy."

"Yes. Very."

The man studied Team Leader Choi's calm response with an odd look, then turned to me.

"You're Jin Taekyung, right? You're even better-looking in person than you are on-screen. No wonder the women's online communities went wild."

"Whoa, really…? Wait, who are you?"

"As you've probably guessed, I'm not a reporter trying to get an interview. I run a Guild in Incheon."

"Oh."

I could more or less guess what he wanted without asking.

Another recruitment offer, probably.

I was used to it by now.

Ever since I became famous, Guild after Guild had approached me.

Taking down a group of ogres single-handedly had proven my ability, and all the media exposure had given me plenty of publicity.

To them, I was a highly desirable "product" in more ways than one.

"Here. My business card."

By now, I had become a master at turning people down.

I accepted the card and put on the most natural smile I could manage.

“I’m sorry, but I’m not considering changing Guilds at the moment.”

“Really?”

“Yes. I’m quite satisfied with my current Guild. They were also the first to reach out to me.”

At my immediate answer, a faint smile flickered across Team Leader Choi’s lips in the rearview mirror.

The man looked back and forth between Team Leader Choi and me, then rubbed his chin.

“That’s a shame.”

“I’ll get in touch another time.”

“Still, there’s no harm in having a cup of coffee together, right? I’m a fan.”

“Pardon?”

“Thirty minutes. No, fifteen should be enough. I’m a busy man myself, so I can’t come by often.”

What the hell was this guy talking about?

Making a recruitment offer in front of Team Leader Choi was already incredibly rude, but now he was simply doing whatever he pleased.

He’s crossing the line.

That was the look I was giving the man as I wondered how to deal with him when —

“That’s strange. Did I misread the interview?”

“…?”

“You said it in *Weekly Hunters*. You said I was your favorite Hunter.”

I blinked.

Only then did I realize who he was—and why he had seemed so familiar.

“C-Could you be…?”

The man grinned at my reaction.

“That hurts. I went to the trouble of giving you my business card, and you didn’t even look at it properly.”

I hurriedly lowered my gaze to the card.

The metal business card gleamed gold as though it had been plated, and clear letters were engraved across its surface.

> **Star Guild CEO Won Myunghoon**

“W-Whoa!”

Seeing me splutter like Mute Samryong,[1105] the man—no, the A-rank Hunter Won Myunghoon—reached through the half-open window and offered me his hand.

"Nice to meet you, Taekyung."

Won Myunghoon.

He was thirty-nine years old, and his birthday was April 1. He stood 185 centimeters[1106] tall, weighed eighty kilograms,[1107] and had a well-proportioned physique.

While preparing for the physical education college entrance exams, he awakened as an A-rank Hunter on his twentieth birthday. With his exceptional ability and good looks, he earned a reputation as a man who had it all.

"Do you think that's all? He has an amazing personality, too. He donates often, and there are countless heartwarming stories about him. He even runs a scholarship foundation…"

Team Leader Choi, who had been listening to my endless stream of information, asked with an incredulous expression,

"How do you know all that? Why have you memorized his physical stats and even his birthday?"

"I told you. He's my favorite Hunter."

It was something I said at least once in every interview.

The people I respected most were my parents. My favorite Hunter was Won Myunghoon.

"…Even so. At this point, isn't it practically love?"

"What a horrifying thing to say. He's more like a role model. The Won Myunghoon Syndrome. Haven't you heard of it?"

"I haven't."

"Oh, dear…"

"What's with that pitying look?"

Because I feel sorry for you for not knowing how cool Won Myunghoon is.

Things were very different now, but up through my school days, Won Myunghoon's influence had been tremendous.

Being an A-rank Hunter was impressive enough, but he also had incredible star power. Whenever you turned on the television, his face was there.

Back then, he had been the very definition of an all-around entertainer.

"Movies, dramas, commercials. He could sing, too, so he even released albums."

[1105] Mute Samryong is the title character of a Korean short story.

[1106] 185 centimeters is about 6 ft 1 in.

[1107] Eighty kilograms is about 176 lb.

“You mean he was a singer as well? A Hunter?”

“Team Leader, you’d recognize the songs if you heard them. *Go*, *Coward*, *I Don’t Know Hunters*, *Escape*… He had tons of hits. He even demolished Japan’s Unicorn chart.”

He had been the role model of countless aspiring Hunters and one of the few male singers welcomed at military morale-boosting performances.

I hummed a few lines as a demonstration, and Team Leader Choi showed a flicker of recognition.

“Oh, I think I’ve heard *I Don’t Know Hunters* before.”

“Right? It’s still on the popular karaoke charts. Anyway, that’s how famous Myunghoon hyung[1108] is. There’s even a saying that any Korean man who doesn’t know Won Myunghoon is either a spy or a monster.”

“Is living abroad for a long time really enough to get me called a monster?”

“Who called you a monster? You’re overreacting.”

“Hoo.”

Team Leader Choi shook his head, then suddenly looked puzzled.

“But even taking all that into account, the name Won Myunghoon feels strangely unfamiliar.”

“When did you return to Korea, Team Leader?”

“Three years ago.”

“Ah, then you might not know about that incident. It was pretty shocking, so everyone in the media keeps quiet about it.”

“An incident?”

“Yes. Though I suppose it has already been eight years. What happened was…”

Just then, Won Myunghoon, who had briefly stepped away to use the restroom, came walking toward us from a distance, waving.

“Team Leader, Myunghoon hyung[1109] is calling me. I’ll get going.”

“…Go ahead. I have about thirty minutes to spare anyway, so I’ll look at some clothes in the department store nearby.”

“Yes, yes.”

I answered vaguely and ran toward Won Myunghoon.

He let out a quiet laugh at the sight of me. His smile looked so youthful that it was hard to believe he would turn forty in just a few months.

“What about your Team Leader?”

[1108] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

[1109] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

"He went to take care of something. More importantly, hyung,[1110] you can speak casually with me."

"Hyung?[1111] The age gap between us is too large for that."

"Oh, come on. These days, twelve years practically makes us the same age."

"Should I, then?"

"Yes."

"Haha. I'm glad to have a good younger brother like you, Taekyung."

"…!"

I trembled with emotion.

Good heavens. Won Myunghoon and I were now hyung[1112] and dongsaeng.[1113]

If Jinho hyung,[1114] who had once even managed Won Myunghoon's fan café, found out about this, he would cling to my trouser leg and refuse to let go. He would insist that the three of us swear a Peach Garden Oath[1115] together.

Not a chance.

A pleased smile spread across my face.

Drunk on happiness, I followed Won Myunghoon into a nearby café. A male part-time employee in his early twenties was reading a book behind the counter. He looked up with a mechanical customer-service smile.

"Welcome. May I take your or—"

A brief silence followed.

Then a breathy gasp escaped his lips.

Of course.

He was a hardcore Won Myunghoon fanboy, too. I nudged Won Myunghoon in the side with my elbow and whispered,

"As expected of you, Myunghoon hyung.[1116] You're still incredibly popular."

"Haha, this is embarrassing. It's been a while since I gave anyone an autograph."

Won Myunghoon laughed awkwardly.

Feeling proud for no reason, I puffed out my chest.

That was when—

[1110] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

[1111] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

[1112] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

[1113] *Dongsaeng* means a younger sibling and can also refer to a close younger friend.

[1114] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

[1115] The Peach Garden Oath is an oath of brotherhood sworn by three men in *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*.

[1116] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

"Jin Taekyung? You're Jin Taekyung, right?"

"…Huh?"

"From the Outer Ring Road a little while ago! The B-rank Gate!"

"I-I am, yes."

"Wow. That's fucking awesome."

Muttering in amazement, the employee hurriedly pulled out a piece of paper and a pen and held them toward me.

"Could you give me your autograph?"

What on earth was going on?

Not Myunghoon hyung[1117]… me?

I turned around in bewilderment and found myself looking at Won Myunghoon's face.

His gaze was cold, his expression stiff.

It was a side of him I had never seen anywhere before. But the next moment, it vanished like a mirage beneath his warm voice.

"What are you waiting for? You should give him your autograph."

"Pardon? Oh, yes."

The café lights must have been too bright. I must have seen wrong.

With a strange sense of déjà vu, I took the pen.

"What should I write?"

The employee answered eagerly.

"Please write, 'Hye-gyeong, I hope you and Jinwoo have a beautiful relationship.'"

"…"

Oh, for fuck's sake.

The initial awkwardness soon faded, and the moment I sat down, I spent more than twenty minutes enthusiastically showing off my fanboy devotion.

"As you know, hyung,[1118] there aren't that many A-rank Hunters who use spears."

"Hmm. That's true. Quite a few people started with spears, then switched to swords later."

Although spears looked easy to use, they were actually very tricky weapons.

Their reach gave you an advantage, but the problem was that you couldn't always maintain that advantage.

[1117] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

[1118] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

Spears worked well enough in low- and mid-level Gates, but high-level Gates were full of dangers no one could anticipate.

There had even been a time when I considered using a one-handed sword and shield.

“But you stuck with the spear all the way. You even wrote your own manual.”

“That was a long time ago. It must have been… ten years by now.”

“Yes. Exactly ten years ago. I was in my first year of high school, and you were already a ranker.”

Just as there were differences in skill among Peak masters, there were differences among A-rank Hunters.

Of the roughly one hundred thousand Hunters in Korea, the hundred strongest were known as rankers.

“I referred to that manual a lot later, when I was at the training center.”

“Really? I don’t know if it was actually helpful.”

“Of course it was. It helped me a ton.”

“If that’s true, then I’m glad.”

Of course, the manual had only worked up through low-level Gates.

That went without saying in the Murim, where martial arts had developed to a level the modern world couldn’t begin to compare with.

But it helped me a lot back then.

The easiest way to explain it was that the manual had been written at the level of a novice.

You couldn’t teach an ant how a tiger moved.

After I finished praising him from every possible angle, Won Myunghoon tilted his lukewarm coffee cup.

“That’s all in the past.”

“You’re still in your prime and actively working.”

“No. It’s been a long time since I lost my ranker status, and people have mostly forgotten about me.”

“…Hmm.”

Was this because of that incident?

It was unfortunate, but I couldn’t deny it completely. Over the past eight years, countless star Hunters had emerged who could match or surpass Won Myunghoon, and the public had cheered for brighter lights.

“It wasn’t until last year that I finally thought about starting again. As it happened, I also took over a Guild from an acquaintance who was about to retire.”

“The Star Guild?”

I had discreetly searched for it earlier.

Star Guild was the name Won Myunghoon had given it after taking over. Before that, it had been a sizable, established Guild that ranked among the top three in Incheon.

"Yeah. A few lines appeared in the news, but that was the end of it. Did you know about it?"

"Last year… I'm sorry. I was a little busy back then."

It wasn't just then. For the past several years, I had repeated the same routine day after day.

Raids, goshiwon,[1119] raids.

At the end of the day, I went home to sleep and eat, then headed back out to fight monsters.

Even if I had heard the news, I would have forgotten it soon enough. To me, Won Myunghoon was already a fond memory, not someone who belonged to the present.

"There's no reason to apologize."

Won Myunghoon smiled bitterly and continued.

"It's not like I'm the only flash in the pan. I suppose that was simply the limit of what I could achieve."

A flash in the pan.

It might have been true because his active career had been so short, but in another sense, it was wrong.

A star?

Even if he had appeared in a few movies, dramas, and commercials and released some albums, Won Myunghoon was first and foremost a Hunter.

He had beaten the incredibly low odds of awakening, and thanks to that, he had seized tremendous wealth and fame.

Even though he had gone through an unfortunate incident…

Maybe this is him returning to his original self.

Despite my lingering unease, I nodded.

It wasn't that my thought was wrong. It was simply different. I had no desire to bring it up and make the atmosphere uncomfortable.

"I see."

"Then I heard about you. You were incredible. It felt like I was looking at my old self."

"M-Me?"

"Yeah. I searched for and read your interviews. I was happy and grateful to hear that you were such an enthusiastic fan of mine. Thanks to you, I even received offers to appear on television from several places."

[1119] A *goshiwon* is a Korean boarding house offering small, inexpensive rooms.

“Oh.”

Had my interview actually helped Won Myunghoon?

I was scratching my chin with an awkward smile when—

A hand clamped around mine.

“Taekyung. Can I make you an offer?”

“…Hyung?[1120]”

Won Myunghoon gripped my hand tightly and spoke with a serious expression.

“Transfer to our Guild. I’ll take responsibility for you, Taekyung. I’ll turn you into a star Hunter.”

[1120] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend with whom he is close.

Chapter 212

“Transfer to our Guild. I’ll take responsibility for you, Taekyung. I’ll turn you into a star Hunter.”

I blinked.

“A star… Hunter?”

“Yeah. A star Hunter.”

Won Myunghoon continued with absolute confidence.

“Times have changed. People go crazy for Hunters. They envy us for the abilities they don’t have. You know that too, don’t you, Taekyung?”

“That’s true.”

“Do you know what the kids around me wanted to be when I was in elementary school? President. Astronaut. But these days? Children and adults alike all want to be Hunters.”

Wealth and fame.

Those were the two words most people associated with being a Hunter.

Even now, decades after the Great Cataclysm ended, they don’t want to think about the fact that hundreds of Hunters still die in Gates every year.

“You have everything the public wants. Good looks, buzz, and a fresh character unlike anything they’ve seen before.”

Won Myunghoon’s face flushed with excitement. His heated voice continued.

“But how long will that last? The public gets excited quickly and loses interest even faster.”

“Hyung.[1121]”

“If you let this opportunity pass, you won’t even become a flash-in-the-pan star, Taekyung. Fortunately, it isn’t too late yet. If you start getting professional management now, appear on television, and work on your image…”

“Wait, wait. Hyung.[1122]”

“Huh? Oh. Right.”

Won Myunghoon fell silent, and I scratched my chin.

I hadn’t expected the conversation to go in this direction, but I might as well make things clear while I had the chance.

“You said you weren’t going to try to recruit me. You told Team Leader Choi that, too.”

“I did. But Taekyung, this is a really good opportunity.”

“Uh, I’m sorry, but I have no intention of changing Guilds.”

[1121] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

[1122] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

Won Myunghoon opened and closed his mouth as if he was about to say something, then nodded.

“Right. That’s understandable at your age. Then let’s forget about changing Guilds. How about signing with an entertainment agency instead? It’s pretty common these days.”

“An entertainment agency?”

“Yeah. I happen to own a major stake in one.”

Holding contracts with two Guilds was illegal, but there was nothing wrong with engaging in other kinds of work.

Just as he’d said, it was no longer unusual for high-ranking Hunters to sign with entertainment or management agencies.

But I answered without hesitation.

“No, I don’t need an agency either.”

“What?”

“I’m satisfied with what I have now.”

“…You’re satisfied?”

“Yes.”

Won Myunghoon frowned.

“Taekyung. You don’t seem to understand what I’m saying.”

“You’re saying I won’t become a star if I let this opportunity pass, right? That’s fine. I didn’t do any of this because I wanted to be one.”

“I know. I know, but think it over one more time. Just one regular television show and a few major commercials could bring in billions of won[1123]—even tens of billions of won.[1124] Can’t you tell just by looking at me?”

Won Myunghoon spread both arms wide. From head to toe, he was dressed in luxury brands whose names and prices I couldn’t even begin to guess.

I suddenly remembered an Internet article I had seen in the past.

> **A-Rank Hunter Won Myunghoon Purchases Building Worth Tens of Billions of Won[1125] in Cheongdam-dong**

The man from that article—the man I had admired and envied endlessly—was standing right in front of me.

[1123] “Billions of won” here refers to roughly 2–9 billion won, or about $1.4–6.4 million and €1.3–5.8 million.

[1124] “Tens of billions of won” here refers to roughly 20–90 billion won, or about $14–64 million and €13–58 million.

[1125] “Tens of billions of won” here refers to roughly 20–90 billion won, or about $14–64 million and €13–58 million.

"I saw your interview. You've been pretty busy. Isn't it time you enjoyed life a little? I heard your dream was to own a building."

"That's true."

It had changed a little, but it was still one of the goals I wanted to achieve.

When I nodded readily, Won Myunghoon flashed me a grin.

"Then signing with an entertainment agency would be much faster than focusing on Guild work. You wouldn't have to fight monsters in dangerous Gates, either. All you'd have to do is spend a few hours working in a nice, cool studio. Though full makeup can feel a little stifling. Ha-ha."

"Oh, really?"

"Of course. You just need to get used to smiling brightly and delivering your lines in front of a camera."

"Then I'd probably prefer Gates. I'm more the physical type, and I don't like feeling stifled."

"…What?"

"I also swear a lot in everyday life. It wouldn't pass broadcast standards. Even if I attracted attention for no reason, my family would just suffer like they are now."

"T-Taekyung."

I continued speaking as I watched his obvious bewilderment.

"And as for owning a building, I can become a building owner without doing television or commercials. It'll take some time, but still."

"What are you talking about? A-rank Hunters make a lot of money, sure, but do you have any idea how expensive land in Gangnam is?"

"Gangnam?"

"Yeah. Do you even know the current price per pyeong[1126] there—?"

I blinked blankly, then let out a quiet laugh.

"Why Gangnam? I can just buy a building near my house."

"Huh?"

"A three-story neighborhood commercial building would still make me a building owner. I've never even considered Gangnam."

"…A neighborhood commercial building?"

"Yes. It'd be close, so it would be easy to visit, and the rent would come in like clockwork. If Mom says she's bored after quitting her job, I could set her up with a little snack bar[1127] or something."

"A snack bar?"

The more I said, the more Won Myunghoon's expression twisted. Had I said something wrong?

[1126] A *pyeong* is a Korean unit of area equal to 3.31 m^2 (35.6 ft^2).

[1127] The Korean term refers to a casual eatery serving inexpensive snacks and light meals.

"Hyung?[1128]"

"…"

"Myunghoon hyung.[1129] Are you all right?"

Won Myunghoon's lips moved soundlessly before he let out a trembling breath.

"Taekyung."

"Yes, hyung.[1130]"

"Can you—can you really be satisfied with that?"

"You saw my interview. Until a few months ago, I was an F-rank Hunter. Now I make dozens of times more without having to work myself to death like I did back then. What's the problem?"

I had no debt, and I had gotten my house back.

Public attention? Fame? I'd already had more than enough of both in the Murim and the modern world.

More than anything, I'd learned just how exhausting and unpleasant the spotlight could be in real life.

I'd also realized what kind of life would make my family and me happier.

"So this is enough for me. Team Leader Choi already showed me a huge pile of commercial offers. There were too many, so I'm planning to pick a few, film them, and then focus on the Guild again."

I could make plenty of money without entering the entertainment industry.

Won Myunghoon remained silent for a long time after I finished speaking. Finally, his lips parted.

"I see. I understand."

"You're not offended because I turned you down, are you?"

"…Of course not."

Just then, the phone on the table vibrated. I didn't even need to check who was calling. It was Team Leader Choi.

I looked at the time and realized that we had gone well past the thirty minutes we'd agreed on.

"Hyung,[1131] I think I should get going."

"Already? You must be busy."

"The Association contacted me and asked me to get my rank reassessed today. I got your number today, so I'll contact you again soon."

"Then I'll see you next time. It was nice meeting you."

[1128] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

[1129] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

[1130] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

[1131] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

“Let’s go to a coin karaoke room[1132] next time. I’ll practice your song before then.”

“A coin karaoke room?[1133] Sounds good.”

Just thinking about hearing him perform the original version of *Coward*, my signature song, live already made my heart race. Maybe I should ask Jinho hyung[1134] to come along, too.

“Then I’ll be going. Don’t forget your promise.”

Won Myunghoon nodded with a faint smile as I left the café.

The black sedan parked by the roadside honked.

“Sir, may I clear your cup?”

Won Myunghoon didn’t answer the part-time worker’s question. He stared silently at the empty coffee cup before abruptly speaking.

“Do you perhaps not know who I am?”

“Pardon?”

“Won Myunghoon. Haven’t you heard of me?”

“Of course I have. You released a few famous songs, didn’t you?”

The part-time worker gave an awkward smile and continued.

“Actually, I just looked you up. You’re much more famous than I thought. I only saw you on television a few times when I was young, so I didn’t remember you very well…”

“You looked me up.”

His voice was as dry as sand.

The smile slowly vanished from the part-time worker’s face.

After nervously watching him for a moment, the worker quietly returned to the counter. Some time later, a familiar melody began playing throughout the café, and the corner of Won Myunghoon’s mouth twisted.

It was his own song, released ten years ago.

All of it had become a relic of the past.

“Who does that bastard think he’s mocking…?”

His low voice was buried beneath the music. Won Myunghoon rose from his seat.

His thoughts were consumed by a single person.

Jin Taekyung—a dayfly Hunter who, until only a few months ago, had scraped by going from one F-rank Gate to another.

[1132] A coin karaoke room lets customers pay to sing individual songs rather than rent a room by the hour.

[1133] A coin karaoke room lets customers pay to sing individual songs rather than rent a room by the hour.

[1134] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or older male friend.

But now he was someone who received the public's attention and affection.

"A coin karaoke room,[1135] my ass… Some lucky bastard gets one flash of fame and forgets his place."

Muttering under his breath, Won Myunghoon put on his sunglasses.

His expensive, flashy outfit drew the eyes of people passing on the street, but not one of them recognized him.

"Congratulations, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

The Bucheon Hunter Association president, a middle-aged man with hair more than half gray, handed me a card with a genial smile.

About half the size of my palm, the card gleamed silver from edge to edge.

Platinum.

The card was made of actual platinum, and everyone dreamed of possessing one, even if only in their sleep.

It means I've gained that much wealth and fame.

But perhaps because I'd fully expected this, I felt surprisingly calm as I accepted the card from the Association president amid the barrage of flashes from countless cameras.

I'm a Peak master. Becoming an A-rank Hunter is no big deal.

Still, I felt pretty good.

I grinned and waved at the cameras, and the Association president asked in a robotic tone,

"So, Mr. Jin Taekyung. How do you feel right now?"

Obviously, I feel fantastic.

I was just about to answer when—

Ding.

> **System** - You have earned the **A-Rank Hunter** achievement. - Achievement Reward granted. - Level Up! - You have gained 20 Bonus Points! - Fame increases greatly!

"Oh, fuck."

"…!"

"…!"

"…Ah."

[1135] A coin karaoke room lets customers pay to sing individual songs rather than rent a room by the hour.

Right. There are cameras here.

The Association president froze, his face stricken. The broadcasting staff looked as though they couldn't believe their ears. Team Leader Choi lowered his head with the hollow expression of a man overcome by post-nut clarity.

I'm fucked.

This had to be one of the worst broadcast disasters in history.

Feeling my throat grow painfully dry, I whispered to the Association president,

"They'll edit that out, right? You have to make sure they do."

"Edit it out? Mr. Jin Taekyung, are you out of your mind?"

The Association president's voice sank ominously low. He looked ready to grab me by the collar on the spot.

"Edit my ass. This is live. What do you call it? An iTube live stream."

"What?"

"Can't you see the monitors in front of us? More than fifty thousand people are watching right now."

"…"

Shit. He's right.

There had been so many people and machines around that I hadn't noticed, but now I saw five or six monitors set up below the podium, each displaying the Association president and me.

The chat beside the video looked ready to explode from the sheer volume of messages.

"Uh, what do we do?"

"What do you mean, what do we do? Apologize immediately!"

The Association president snapped at me, his face bright red. Just then, the camera director at the very front mouthed something.

"The reaction is good?"

"Huh?"

"What?"

What is that supposed to mean?

I looked at the chaotic chat window. Dozens—no, hundreds—of messages had scrolled past in only a few seconds, but my extraordinary dynamic vision caught every little detail.

> ㄴ □□□□□
>
> ㄴ □□□Taekyung the Lord, have you lost your mind?□□□□
>
> ㄴ Not Taekyung the Lord. He's Lord Fuck now□□□□□

> ㄴ Best acceptance speech ever□□□□□ Usually they start with religion or family, then finish with, “And thank you, Minsik, Changsu, Hyerim,” or something□□□□□
>
> ㄴ Lord Fuck doesn’t do any of that. I knew what he was like from the moment he beat down an ogre on his way to work, dragging his slippers□□
>
> ㄴ ??? : Oh, fuck.
>
> ㄴ Look at the Association president’s face□□□□□□ The old man’s soul left his body.
>
> ㄴ Taekyung, nobody cares, so just do whatever you want□□□□ I’d probably laugh it off even if you insulted my parents.
>
> ㄴ May your parents live long and healthy lives.
>
> ㄴ ? What the fuck is this guy?

It was a complete mess, but one thing was clear.

The broadcast disaster I’d caused by accident was a massive hit.

Chapter 213

"Netizens have some serious firepower. Everyone's going crazy over the press conference."

Team Leader Choi's relaxed voice came from behind me.

Ssshhhwing!

At the same time, razor-sharp claws slashed through the air. I simply leaned my head back to dodge them and muttered,

"Tell me about it. I thought I'd caused a broadcast disaster, but somehow it all worked out."

"On top of that, everyone's praising you for going straight to a Gate as soon as the press conference ended."

"Isn't it normal for a Hunter to go on a raid?"

"That's why image is so important. You know the saying, don't you? Take a shit, and you'll become famous."

"...I don't think that's quite it."

Shhhk! Crack!

I knocked aside and shattered every claw aimed at my head, shoulders, and chest.

The creature staggered back with a pained howl. Just as I was about to close in, Team Leader Choi asked,

"Would you like to take one next time?"

"Take what?"

"A shit."

"I'll pass."

I answered firmly and swung my spear shaft.

Wham!

Something crunched, and the creature charging in from the side slammed straight into the ground.

It stood two meters tall[1136]—a massive, gray-furred, bipedal wolf with nothing left above its shoulders. I had blown its head off through sheer strength alone.

A System notification rang out at the same time.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 73 Lycanthrope!

You have gained EXP!

[1136] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

The lycanthropes that had watched their fellow die let out a chorus of growls and howls.

- Grrrrr.
- Awooooo.

Their long, vertically slit yellow pupils trembled.

Seeing them hesitate, Team Leader Choi remarked as though he had just realized something.

“This is the first time I’ve seen lycanthropes look so docile.”

“They’re good at controlling their anger. Maybe being half-human means they picked up that trait too.”

Hotheads who claimed to have anger-management issues always followed the same pattern.

They acted like Lü Bu[1137] around anyone weaker than them, but the moment they found themselves in front of some muscular tough guys, they became the politest people in the world.

And once they lose the momentum, it’s over.

Slash!

I flicked the sticky blood off my spearhead and beckoned to the creatures with one finger.

“Come on, you sons of bitches.”

- Whiiine.

Their ears had folded halfway back, and their tails were tucked between their legs.

The moment a wolf became a dog, the fight was as good as over.

“You little bastards are cute.”

As I walked toward them with a grin, Team Leader Choi said,

“If possible, please handle them cleanly.”

“Why?”

“So we can take some proof shots. We’re going to post them on the Peace Guild’s official social-media account.”

“…”

“Too much pixelation would be a shame. People prefer things uncensored.”

Ah. He had a point.

- Awooooooooo!

As expected, the boss was different from the rest.

[1137] Lü Bu was a Chinese military general famed for his prowess in battle.

Its roar was packed with ferocity and killing intent. Its body was far larger than those of the other lycanthropes, and silver fur covered it from head to toe.

Every inch of it radiated the presence of a boss monster.

“Wow. You’re impressive.”

As I admired it, I made a decision.

I would give this one special treatment.

“One Annihilation.”

Krrrunch. Thud.

The monster’s massive body, a gaping hole torn through its chest, toppled like a rotting old tree.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 83 Silver-Mane Lycanthrope!
You have perfectly cleared the B-Rank Gate, The Lycanthrope’s Black Forest!
You have gained a substantial amount of EXP!
The exit has opened because you defeated the boss monster.

Kiiiiing.

Once the conditions were met, a Gate exit appeared in the center of the clearing. But I still had something left to do.

“All right. Time for the fun part—cleanup.”

The sight of the corpses scattered everywhere filled me with satisfaction.

I was heading toward them with the heart of a farmer bringing in the harvest when Team Leader Choi spoke.

“About Won Myunghoon.”

“Yes?”

I turned at the sudden sound of his voice behind me.

He sat on a flat rock, his entire body protected by a shield spell, staring at a custom-built phone.

There was something odd about his expression.

“Myunghoon hyung[1138]?”

“Yes. What happened to Mr. Won Myunghoon eight years ago?”

I had no idea why he was suddenly curious.

[1138] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him.

I had been a student back then, but I was such a huge fan that I knew the whole story by heart. Explaining all of it would take forever, though.

“Look it up. Everything comes up if you search Sonamu Wiki.[1139]”

“People say you should stay off Sonamu Wiki.[1140]”

“…They have a point.”

“Just give me a brief explanation. Of all the people around me, you seem to know the most about Mr. Won Myunghoon.”

“Well, if you put it that way…”

I began talking as I skinned a lycanthrope with my dagger.

“Eight years ago, Myunghoon hyung’s[1141] career was on the decline. Every movie, drama, and album he released bombed, and then allegations of tax evasion were piled on top of that.”

“That isn’t particularly unusual.”

“No. That industry is always full of scandals.”

“I skimmed through the articles. It seems he was cleared of the tax-evasion allegations.”

“Yes. That ended without any real trouble.”

But that wasn’t the end of it.

Once mud had been splashed onto his clean image, all kinds of speculative articles and rumor sheets about Won Myunghoon began circulating online.

In the end, Won Myunghoon—already past his prime and going through a difficult time—decided to step away from the public eye.

“He said he’d spent too long looking elsewhere and would devote himself to his duties as a Hunter for a while.”

“And then that incident happened?”

“Oh, you read that article?”

“I just did.”

Team Leader Choi held out his phone. The screen, about the size of an adult’s palm, displayed a headline from eight years ago in bold type.

> **Myeongdong Station Mutated Gate Catastrophe, Around 30 Dead Including A-Rank Hunter Do Minsu… Surviving Won Myunghoon: “Minsu, I’m Sorry.”**

[1139] *Sonamu* means “pine tree” in Korean. Sonamu Wiki alludes to Namu Wiki, a Korean collaborative encyclopedia.

[1140] *Sonamu* means “pine tree” in Korean. Sonamu Wiki alludes to Namu Wiki, a Korean collaborative encyclopedia.

[1141] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him.

The incident had caused a massive uproar and dominated the news at the time.

“Who is Do Minsu?”

“An A-rank star Hunter who was extremely close to Myunghoon hyung.[1142] His popularity was soaring, but he died after joining him on a cooperative raid as a social outing.”

No one had expected anything like that to happen when they set out for a B-rank Gate in such a lighthearted mood, as though they were going on a picnic.

Especially not with two A-rank Hunters participating.

The domestic media boiled over like a cauldron on hot coals, then quickly went cold.

“It took several years for him to stand trial over that incident and be cleared of the charges.”

After the long legal fight, all that remained was a reputation covered in filth and the public’s indifference.

He appeared on television a few times afterward, but that was all. Unable to make a comeback, he quietly retired from the entertainment industry.

Though I don’t think he’s given up yet.

If he had let go of all his lingering attachments, he wouldn’t have offered to recruit me and promised to turn me into a star Hunter.

In any case, after listening to the whole story, Team Leader Choi gave a small nod.

“I see.”

“But why are you suddenly asking about that?”

“Won Myunghoon’s name is number one in the real-time search rankings. There are already dozens of related articles.”

“Oh, really?”

“And Jin Taekyung is right alongside him at number one.”

“What?”

What was going on? Could two people be tied for first in the real-time search rankings?

As I tilted my head, Team Leader Choi held out his phone again.

A fresh article posted ten minutes earlier filled the screen.

> **Jin Taekyung & Won Myunghoon: Successful Fanboy Transferring to Star Guild?**
>
> **A New Star Hunter Is About to Be Born**

After a brief silence, I tore my eyes away from the screen.

[1142] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him.

Team Leader Choi asked,

“Are you transferring?”

No, what the hell was he talking about?

Hyung,[1143] *I’ll see you again soon.*

I hadn’t expected those words, spoken only a few hours ago when I parted ways with Won Myunghoon, to come true so quickly.

Of course, the place where we met again wasn’t a coin karaoke room[1144] but the Peace Guild House.

“I’m sorry.”

Won Myunghoon had read the article in the middle of work and rushed over immediately. He bowed politely to every Guild member, including me, then explained in a flustered voice,

“I was surprised too. Someone must have seen us meeting and put out a speculative article… I’ve already filed a complaint with the media outlet and arranged for an immediate statement to be released.”

Team Leader Choi, who had been staring at Won Myunghoon, spoke.

“I saw the article saying the story was baseless a few minutes ago. You work quickly.”

“False information needs to be corrected as soon as possible.”

“False information?”

Team Leader Choi’s long fingers tapped the phone screen.

“But it isn’t entirely baseless, is it? Jin Taekyung told me that you offered to recruit him. In a café with other people around, no less.”

“That…”

“Team Leader Choi, let me explain it again.”

I stepped in for the hesitant Won Myunghoon.

Considering the situation, I had no choice but to reveal the conversation we’d had at the café, and I was already feeling a little guilty about it.

“What happened was—”

But before I could continue, Won Myunghoon’s firm voice cut me off.

“It’s true. I offered to recruit him, and Taekyung turned me down. This all happened because of my own selfishness, so I sincerely apologize.”

“Hmm.”

Who was Won Myunghoon, anyway?

[1143] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him.

[1144] A coin karaoke room is a small karaoke booth where customers pay per song.

Won Myunghoon wasn't just an accomplished Hunter. He was a celebrity who had once stood at the very height of popularity.

When someone like him frankly admitted his mistake, accepted responsibility, and bowed with perfect courtesy, there wasn't much left for anyone to say.

It wasn't as though he had seriously violated professional courtesy.

Hunters were professionals, plain and simple. As long as the regulations allowed it, they were free to transfer to another Guild or leave one whenever they wanted.

The dozens of recruitment offers I had received before Won Myunghoon's were no different.

The only difference was that I had arranged a separate meeting with him because I was a fan.

And the subsequent articles about my transfer had already been proven baseless.

Thanks to the swift action from both sides, the situation was already dying down.

Team Leader Choi, who had been deep in thought, finally spoke.

"All right. Let's put this matter to rest."

Won Myunghoon's face brightened.

"I'm relieved to hear you say that. Thank you."

"Not at all. I have no intention of turning a minor incident into something bigger than it is. Besides, our side shares some of the blame."

Im Kkeokjeong, who had been watching the situation carefully, cut in with a good-natured grin.

"Yeah, yeah. Now that's good to see. That's how people should live—understanding each other."

Butler Kim and Song Song nodded in agreement.

The atmosphere inside the Guild House, which had been strangely uncomfortable only ten minutes earlier, had turned warm and friendly.

I'm glad this worked out better than expected.

Soon, Won Myunghoon had a cup of coffee in front of him. Wearing an amiable smile, he chatted about one thing after another.

"Taekyung is incredibly devoted to the Peace Guild. I wanted him so badly that I tried to lure him away, but he wouldn't budge."

"Haha! This guy's always been unbeatable when it comes to loyalty."

"You're all such wonderful people that I suppose he didn't want to leave. Now that I've met you in person, I understand why Taekyung turned me down without a second thought."

"Wow. Mr. Won, you really know how to tell people what they want to hear. When I watched you on television, I thought it was all scripted."

"That earned me plenty of accusations that I was an obnoxious bastard."

It was in the middle of this friendly conversation that Won Myunghoon casually made another proposal.

“What are your schedules like tomorrow? I was wondering if we could go on a raid together.”

“Tomorrow?”

“A raid?”

Everyone reacted differently, but their eyes all turned toward one person.

Team Leader Choi.

On paper, Butler Kim was the Guild Master. But Won Myunghoon had also realized that Team Leader Choi was the real power in the Guild.

“What do you think, Team Leader? This would be a good opportunity to clear up the suspicions raised by the rumor sheets, and it could also be a valuable experience for the Guild members.”

“I’m not sure.”

Maybe it was because I’d grown used to Team Leader Choi by now.

I could sense something subtly uneasy in his expression.

But his hesitation vanished at Won Myunghoon’s next words.

“It’s an A-rank Gate. Fortunately, our Guild obtained permission to raid it this week. It seems like a shame to let the opportunity go to waste.”

“An A-rank Gate?”

“Yes. We’ll also guarantee you the rights to anything that comes out of the Gate.”

Gate qualification reviews were strict.

As a Guild that had only just begun recruiting members, the Peace Guild would need a considerable amount of time before it could enter an A-rank Gate.

“An A-rank Gate…”

Team Leader Choi murmured under his breath, then finally nodded.

Chapter 214

Once the details of the joint raid had been finalized, Won Myunghoon rose from his seat.

“Then I’ll be going.”

“Hyung,[1145] you’re leaving already?”

“It would’ve been nice to have a drink together.”

At Jin Taekyung and Im Kkeokjeong’s regretful tones, Won Myunghoon gave them a genial smile.

“I still have work to do. I am the Guild Master, after all. I can’t cause a mess and then be the only one off having fun.”

“Ah, right.”

After he put it that way, no one could press him to stay.

Telling the others there was no need to walk him out, Won Myunghoon left the Peace Guild House. He strolled away leisurely as he pulled out his phone.

After a few rings, someone answered.

“Yes, CEO.”

“The arrangements are done. We’re holding the joint raid tomorrow at two in the afternoon.”

“That was quick.”

“The bait’s too good. When would people like them ever get a chance to enter an A-rank Gate?”

“Haha. That’s true.”

“We’re only bringing one team from our Guild. You’ve told the guys to keep their mouths shut, right?”

“Don’t you trust me? I handpicked only the ones who know how to follow orders.”

“That’s why you’re Team Leader 1. I’ll be back right away, so choose the list of people participating tomorrow and have it ready.”

“Yes, sir. What about the Peace Guild?”

“This place?”

Won Myunghoon gave a short laugh and continued.

“I came by just in case, but it’s a complete mess. A hodgepodge. They’re a bunch of nobodies without even a proper hierarchy. How impressive could a Guild with only five members possibly be?”

“Even without Jin Taekyung, they still have three B-rank Hunters.”

[1145] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

“That’s all they are. The old man they’ve seated as Guild Master looks like a figurehead. The Team Leader and the woman used to be with the Ares Guild, but they’re nothing worth worrying about. The other one is only D-rank.”

“D-rank? That should make tomorrow’s job easy.”

“Easy?”

The amusement vanished from Won Myunghoon’s voice, leaving it ice-cold.

The sudden change in atmosphere seemed to make the person on the other end flinch. He hurriedly added,

“CEO, that’s not what I meant.”

“Team Leader 1—no, Jonghun.”

“…Yes.”

“Let’s stay sharp. Why do you think I’m personally running Gates at my age? Am I wrong?”

“I’m sorry.”

“All right. If you understand, do better from now on. Watch what you say.”

“Understood, CEO.”

“Good. See you later.”

After ending the call, Won Myunghoon took out his lip gloss and applied it.

He was only a few months shy of forty.

He spent hundreds of millions of won[1146] every year maintaining his appearance, but there was no hiding the passage of time.

“It’s been a while since I was in the spotlight. Maybe I should stop by the salon today.”

Muttering too quietly for anyone to hear, he climbed into the sports car parked by the roadside.

The thought of facing those disgusting monsters again after so long put him in a foul mood. But when he imagined the flower-strewn path awaiting him afterward, he began humming to himself.

The next morning, Jinho hyung[1147] sat across from me at the table, unable to tear his eyes away from his phone.

“You haven’t even eaten. What are you looking at so intently?”

“Articles about you.”

“Again?”

“What do you mean, again? I could read these all day.”

[1146] Hundreds of millions of Korean won is roughly 100–900 million won, or about $71,000–$640,000 and €65,000–€580,000.

[1147] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

Anyone watching him would've thought the articles were about Jinho, not me.

These days, checking the online reaction and reporting it to me had become part of his daily routine. He was practically my manager.

"People like you. There are tons of articles about Won Myunghoon, too."

"Of course there are."

"You two look good together. So heartwarming… I wish Lord Fuck would swear at me, and so on."

"…"

"There's even a guy asking to be tied up and beaten."

The world really was a big place, and it was full of lunatics.

Dumbfounded, I searched for myself. The internet was overflowing with articles about me, while every online community imaginable was packed with nicknames and edited images.

There was even a post summarizing my exploits sitting prominently on the best-posts board.

A Summary of Lord Fuck's Exploits So Far.txt

> Hi. I'm an unemployed guy in my thirties.
>
> I was thinking hard about what useless thing to do today when I became curious about Lord Fuck. Most people who know anything about him probably already know all this, but I figured there might be some people who don't, so I wrote it up.
>
> I couldn't be bothered to move my fingers much, so here's the short version.
>
> 1. Awakened as F-rank at twenty. Spent seven years getting run even harder than a brand-new private, then reawakened.
> 2. But the Hunter Association played its trap card, so he was measured as C-rank at the time. The accepted scholarly consensus is that the Hunter Association is full of idiots.
> 3. The bewildered Lord Fuck was snared by an unknown Guild called the Peace Guild.
> 4. A B-rank Gate erupted while he was going to work in a tracksuit, dragging along slippers. He chewed through the ogres by himself and saved hundreds of people.
> 5. His life turned around. On the day he received his A-rank Hunter ID, he made *that remark* in front of fifty thousand people. Acquired the title "Lord Fuck."

> That's about it. I didn't write anything about his family because I might get sued.
>
> A few media outlets have already been taken down. An unemployed thirtysomething like me would be nothing by comparison. If a complaint lands, I'll get a Mom's Touch across the back, so cut me some slack.[1148]
>
> I ate doenjang jjigae[1149] for breakfast, scratched my balls, and scribbled this together.

Only one thought came to mind after I finished reading.

It's way too short.

If I wrote down everything I'd experienced traveling between the modern world and Murim, even a hundred pages wouldn't be enough.

Well, they're ordinary people who don't know anything. I suppose this is only natural.

I scrolled through the comments packed beneath the post.

Of course, I couldn't read all several hundred of them, so I picked out a few of the best comments.

> ㄴ **(Best comment)** Fuck. I love him.
>
> ㄴ I saw Lord Fuck live, and he swears even more colorfully than my grandma. Did he go to some kind of swearing academy?
>
> ㄴ But it sounds natural. You can't hate him.
>
> ㄴ We've had innocent, good-natured A-rank Hunters appear on TV before, but none of them were ever this down-to-earth. Lol.
>
> ㄴ Yeah, that's why people like him. From the stories he told in the interview about his F-rank days, it sounds like he went through hell. Maybe that's why.
>
> ㄴ Personally, I liked that he went straight to a raid after leaving the Association. It felt like he cared more about a Hunter's true duty than money.
>
> ㄴ Agreed.

> ㄴ **(Best comment)** So what happened to him transferring to the Star Guild? Honestly, I'd rather he just transfer.
>
> ㄴ Completely false. He kept sucking up to Won Myunghoon in every interview, so he went to meet him once, and the story got twisted.

[1148] Mom's Touch is a Korean fast-food chain. The name is used here as a pun on a mother smacking someone across the back.

[1149] *Doenjang jjigae* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybean paste.

> ㄴ Sucking…?
>
> ㄴ There's my material for today.
>
> ㄴ Lord Fuck will do it for free.
>
> ㄴ There are so many crazy bastards here.

> ㄴ **(Best comment)** Lord Fuck already has a permanent free pass from criticism, and now Won Myunghoon's suddenly getting carried by the scruff of his neck.
>
> ㄴ Seriously. I'd forgotten Won Myunghoon's name. I vaguely remember seeing an article a few years ago saying he was cleared in that case.
>
> ㄴ Wasn't he popular? Why did he disappear?
>
> ㄴ He was. He was at his peak for his entire career, but the problem was that his career was way too short. By today's standards, his persona was too predictable, and his acting wasn't anything special… He only got famous because one of his songs became a hit, and he had tons of fans who were just into his face. Plenty of people still suck up to Won Myunghoon. Jin Taekyung included.
>
> ㄴ Sucking…?
>
> ㄴ This is the same guy from the comment above. Anyway, apparently the Peace Guild and Star Guild are doing a joint raid today. I'm looking forward to it.

The overall reaction from netizens was favorable.

Apparently, appearing on the news once or twice and doing a few magazine interviews had left quite a good impression.

The public opinion of Myunghoon hyung[1150] isn't too bad, either.

Was it nostalgia?

Although an unpleasant incident had gradually pushed him out of the public eye, plenty of people still remembered Won Myunghoon.

Jinho, sitting across from me, was one of them.

"Don't forget to get Won Myunghoon's autograph, okay?"

"Got it. I'm going to get a callus in my ear."

I gave Jinho, who was as giddy as a teenage girl, a halfhearted answer and rose from my seat.

We'd eaten breakfast late, so it was already past ten. We needed to leave soon if we wanted to finish the final checks before the raid.

"Damn it. If I were a Hunter, I'd get to raid with Won Myunghoon too."

[1150] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

Jinho muttered wistfully, envy written all over his face.

To be honest, I was a little nervous myself.

An A-rank Gate with Myunghoon hyung.[1151]

Part of it was that I would be entering an A-rank Gate for the first time, but the thought of raiding alongside one of my old idols also filled me with anticipation.

I never thought I'd live to see a day like this.

My heart pounding with excitement, I left the house.

If mid- and low-level Gates were grains of sand, an A-rank Gate was a massive boulder.

Even in Korea, a country famous for having so many Gates despite its small territory, A-rank Gates were rare. Competition for the right to raid them was fierce.

For the Peace Guild, which still had only five official members, this was unquestionably an opportunity that would normally be almost impossible to obtain.

And yet…

Why is everyone so relaxed?

Even I, who considered myself the strongest person here, had to swallow nervously. But Team Leader Choi, Butler Kim, and Song-i looked as calm as if they were heading to the neighborhood supermarket.

"Did they change this to a B-rank Gate without telling me?"

Team Leader Choi answered in his usual calm voice.

"It is an A-rank Gate."

"Then why are you all so composed? Did everyone secretly take Cheongsimhwan?[1152]"

"Song-i and I have been to plenty of them. Back when we were with the Ares Guild."

"Ah. Right."

Ares was the greatest Guild in Korea—no, in Asia—and a major Guild recognized throughout the world.

Its strength was one thing, but every last member was part of the elite. There was no reason they couldn't handle an A-rank Gate.

"And as for Butler Kim…"

At Team Leader Choi's words, Butler Kim smiled.

"I saw more than enough of them during the Great Cataclysm."

[1151] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

[1152] *Cheongsimhwan* is a traditional herbal medicine taken to calm the mind and body.

"…"

"Back when I was active, monster armies marched down the highways, and flocks of Drakes flew through the sky. Things like that."

What the hell? That was terrifying.

As expected of someone from the Great Cataclysm generation. His level of experience was on an entirely different scale.

Butler Kim was publicly known as a B-rank Hunter, but he was powerful enough to put Im Chunsoo—an A-rank Hunter and the Guild Master of Sangdong Guild—through PT drills.

What on earth is someone like him doing here?

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim's true identities and relationship remained a mystery.

They knew I was curious yet still refused to tell me. They must have their reasons.

That aside…

I turned my gaze toward the last Guild member.

The one person I'd been most worried about.

Contrary to my expectations, Im Kkeokjeong was leaning back against the car seat with a calm expression.

"Are you all right?"

"Of course I'm all right—urrrgh!"

"…"

Fine, my ass. You're nervous as hell.

Perhaps he knew it himself, because he quickly pulled out the black plastic bag he had brought in advance and buried his face in it.

After finishing a bout of retching, Im Kkeokjeong muttered with a deathly pale face,

"I'm fine. Really."

Im Kkeokjeong might have been fine, but I wasn't. The very act of letting a D-rank Hunter enter an A-rank Gate was a dangerously reckless decision.

"Uh, I'm only saying this just in case…"

As soon as I cautiously began speaking, Im Kkeokjeong shook his head.

"No. The Guild Master and Team Leader gave me permission, too. I can't keep imposing on everyone forever. I need to gain some experience."

"Hmm."

"Taekyung, I have a wife and children to think about. I'm well past the age where I'd make a decision out of pride or childish bravado. Even if something happens…"

"Ah, I understand. That's enough."

I hurriedly cut him off before he could say anything more ominous.

He must have been worrying a lot lately because his rank was so much lower than those of the other Guild members, but he had taken it far too far.

"We're going in safely and coming out safely. The Star Guild is sending two A-rank Hunters too. And Myunghoon hyung[1153] used to be a ranker."

Between the two Guilds, there were four A-rank Hunters and more than ten B-rank Hunters. They had more than enough strength to cover for Kkeokjeong.

Team Leader Choi nodded as well.

"Nothing will go wrong."

He was a cautious man. If he had decided to let Im Kkeokjeong participate, it was because he was confident it would be safe.

"Yeah. It will."

A faint smile appeared on Im Kkeokjeong's lips.

Just then, tall buildings began rising into view beyond the car windows.

It looked like an entire village—no, a small city.

Its residents and guards were soldiers carrying firearms and Hunters decked out in expensive equipment.

"Wow."

Unlike me, who let out an exclamation, Team Leader Choi frowned.

"This place…"

After surveying the scene outside, he turned toward the driver of the limousine bus Won Myunghoon had sent especially for us.

"I think you may have brought us to the wrong place."

"What? That can't be."

The driver's eyes widened as though he had no idea what Team Leader Choi meant.

"The A-rank Gate, Black Wyvern's Nest. This is the right place. I entered it into the GPS and came straight here."

"Black Wyvern's Nest? There must have been some mistake. Won Myunghoon said…"

"Who's Won Myunghoon? I work for the bus company, so I don't know him. I came exactly where I was told to go."

Team Leader Choi and the driver's voices buzzed in my ears.

Suddenly, my stomach began to churn, and a sharp pain throbbed through my head.

Amid the confusion, a roar I'd heard three years ago tore through my mind.

Kyaaaaaaar!

Eyes stained pitch-black and a tongue like a blade.

[1153] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

The wingbeats that had brought down the cave and the claws that had torn my teammates apart flashed vividly before my eyes, blurring my vision.

The Black Wyvern.

I never thought we’d meet again like this.

Chapter 215

Wyvern.

One of the high-tier monsters classified as dragonkin, along with drakes.

Its body was larger than an airplane's, its hide was tough, and its intelligence was high enough for it to use magic.

It possessed enough power to be called a small dragon without exaggeration.

The creature I had encountered three years ago was something that could not—and should not—have emerged from an E-Rank Gate.

Kyaaaaaaar!

I opened my eyes at the monster's roar, echoing in the distance.

Instead of a dark, humid cave, I saw a clear sky and the familiar faces of my Guild members.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, are you all right?"

"Taekyung."

Their voices were full of concern. I forced my rigid expression to relax.

"Yes. My stomach felt a little queasy. I guess I got motion sickness."

"Motion sickness? You?"

Motion sickness in a Peak master—or rather, an A-Rank Hunter. Even I knew it was a pathetic excuse.

Even Song-i, who had been keeping her distance from me lately, looked concerned as she asked, "Would you like me to cast a healing spell?"

"No, I'm fine."

I gave her a feeble smile like the protagonist of *The Last Leaf*[1154] and added, "Just having you beside me is healing enough, Song-i."

"…Ah. Yes."

Im Kkeokjeong leaned close and whispered in my ear, "You bastard. How the hell did you come up with a line like that?"

"Was it bad?"

"No, it was insane. The moment I heard it, electricity shot through my whole body."

Was it really that effective?

My mind had been completely blank, so I'd just blurted out the first thing that came to me.

But judging by Song-i, who had frozen like someone struck by lightning, it did seem to have worked.

[1154] *The Last Leaf* is a short story by O. Henry about a gravely ill woman who believes she will die when the last leaf falls from a vine.

Why does it feel like I landed a critical hit?

Meanwhile, the throbbing in my temples and the nausea in my stomach had both subsided.

Just as I was taking a deep breath, the door of the limousine bus we had been riding in opened, and someone appeared.

“Everyone’s here. But…”

Won Myunghoon trailed off at the tense atmosphere inside the bus, then turned to Team Leader Choi.

“Did something happen?”

“Yes. Something serious enough that we need to talk.”

Team Leader Choi answered firmly, then turned toward me.

“You too, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“The Star Guild got here ages ago. Where’s the Peace Guild?”

“Wait, isn’t that Jin Taekyung?”

“It is. Won Myunghoon’s beside him, so it’s definitely him.”

“Take pictures quickly. Get ready to interview him in a little while.”

Team Leader Choi, Won Myunghoon, and I moved toward a secluded corner.

The reporters and Hunters who had flocked here after hearing the news stared so intently that I could feel their gazes burning into my face.

Once their persistent attention finally drifted away, Team Leader Choi spoke with a grim expression.

“Why was the location suddenly changed?”

“Changed? What do you mean?”

“Wasn’t Manticore’s Jungle supposed to be today’s raid location?”

“What? That can’t be right. Do you have the contract with you?”

“Here. It’s stated clearly.”

Won Myunghoon hurriedly examined the contract Team Leader Choi handed him. His face twisted violently.

“That bastard, the leader of Team One.”

Judging by his reaction, there seemed to have been a mistake somewhere along the way.

After muttering several curses—unusual for him—Won Myunghoon spoke with an awkward expression.

“I’m sorry. One of our employees made a serious mistake. I don’t know what to say.”

“A mistake. I see.”

Team Leader Choi continued in a dry voice.

“I think it would be best to call off today’s raid.”

“What?”

“This isn’t just any Gate. It’s an A-Rank Gate. Entering without perfect preparation could lead to an accident. And…”

Team Leader Choi trailed off for a moment, his gaze flicking toward me.

He had already investigated my past.

He knew I was the sole survivor of the Sangdong Station Mutated Gate incident three years ago. He also knew I was still suffering from the aftereffects.

“Wyverns are still too much for our Guild members. We appreciate the offer, but I think it would be best for both sides if we withdrew here.”

“Team Leader!”

Despite Won Myunghoon’s flustered cry, Team Leader Choi’s attitude remained as sharp as a blade.

“Wyverns are out of the question. At least for now.”

“…”

That was when I abruptly spoke up after watching the situation in silence.

“Let’s do it. The raid.”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Plenty of articles have already gone up online, and all these reporters are here. If we call it off now, won’t people start talking?”

I stared past Team Leader Choi and Won Myunghoon, who stood side by side.

Reporters with cameras hanging from their necks were already watching us carefully as they edged closer.

They’ve got one hell of a nose for a story.

They had clearly sensed the tension and were coming over to investigate.

Before Team Leader Choi could say anything, I quickly cut him off.

“It’s not that I particularly care about the articles. It’s just that I’m all right now.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

Half of that was true. The other half was a lie.

I still wasn’t fine. For the past three years, I had relived the same nightmare over and over, remembering the creature’s roar and my teammates’ screams.

Then I would wake drenched in cold sweat, pretend nothing had happened, and go through another day just like all the others.

But not anymore.

“I can do this. I’m not the same person I was back then.”

I was no longer the utterly powerless F-Rank Hunter I had been. I was a Peak master and an A-Rank Hunter—someone who could stand tall anywhere and call himself strong.

“So it’s fine. No, I want to do it.”

Team Leader Choi stared at me for a long moment, then let out a deep sigh.

“All right. Let’s do it.”

A short while later, we stood before a doorway of ominously rippling mana.

Rolling cameras and incessant flashes captured the members of both Guilds as we began our joint raid.

“Phew.”

I took a deep breath and stepped forward.

Sticky mana coiled around my body as the familiar System notification appeared.

Ding.

> **System** - You have entered **A-Rank Gate, The Black Wyvern’s Nest**. - Upon clearing the Gate, you will receive a Reward commensurate with your performance.

Ssshhh.

When I opened my eyes again, everything around me had changed.

“Huff. Huuuff.”

Im Kkeokjeong, clad in heavy full plate armor, panted raggedly.

An hour had passed since we entered the Gate, and sweat was already pouring down his forehead like rain.

He wasn’t the only one. Most of the more than twenty members of the Star and Peace Guilds trudged along with sweat streaming from their bodies.

Hardly surprising.

I clicked my tongue and looked around.

Beneath the blazing sun, a jungle of trees dozens of meters[1155] tall and bizarre-looking plants stretched endlessly into the distance.

The sight alone was suffocating, and air hotter and more humid than a steam sauna completed the picture.

A primeval forest.

It looked exactly like something out of a dinosaur documentary.

The weather aside, the scenery itself was spectacular.

[1155] Dozens of meters means at least about 20 m (66 ft).

"Wow."

As I let out an involuntary exclamation, someone came over and tapped me on the shoulder.

"Pretty relaxed, aren't you?"

"Oh, Myunghoon hyung.[1156] Weren't you up front?"

Our formation had Won Myunghoon in the lead, me in the middle, and Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim bringing up the rear.

Won Myunghoon flashed his white teeth in a grin.

"You have to check behind you sometimes. Everyone else is struggling, but then I spotted some carefree bastard sightseeing by himself, so I came over."

"What if a wyvern suddenly jumps out?"

"We're still in the jungle zone, so we'll only run into minor monsters here. Wyverns nest on cliffs and mountain peaks. We're nowhere near them yet."

"Seriously?"

"It'll take at least half a day to encounter a wyvern, or a full day if we're unlucky. Enjoy the scenery while you can."

I had known higher-level Gates were larger, but I hadn't expected anything on this scale. I shook my head in disbelief.

"This place is incredible. No wonder they give you raid access for a full week."

"That's how long these raids take. Once you've been through a few A-Rank Gates like this, you'll be sick of them too."

"I don't know about that."

I probably wouldn't.

To me, a Gate had long since stopped being a grueling, tedious workplace. It was a place where I could grow even stronger.

"I'm having fun."

"…Well, I suppose that's possible."

Won Myunghoon gave me an odd look, then handed me something.

"Here. Hold on to this."

"What is it?"

It was a necklace set with a blue jewel. Before I could inspect the Item, Won Myunghoon continued.

"It has a cold spell enchanted into it, so put it on. You're an A-Rank, so you'll be fine for now, but the heat will start draining your Stamina later. You're one of our main combat assets. You need to conserve your strength."

"You don't have to give me something like this, hyung.[1157]"

[1156] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man he is close to.

[1157] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man he is close to.

“I’m not giving it to you. I’m lending it to you, so take good care of it and return it later.”

Even at a glance, it looked incredibly expensive.

I hesitated, but Won Myunghoon kept urging me, so I had no choice but to put it on.

Ding.

> **System** - You have equipped **Yeti’s Necklace**. - A wind from the snowy plains flows from the necklace.

At the same time as the System notification, a chill cold enough to send shivers down my spine wrapped around my entire body.

“It works well.”

“It looks good on you. Keep it on from now on. I need to go deploy the scouting team.”

Won Myunghoon smiled with satisfaction and strode away. The moment his back disappeared from view, I took off the necklace.

I told him I’m really fine.

Won Myunghoon might have taken my words for modesty, but I’d only been stating a fact.

When I opened my Conception and Governor Vessels in the Murim, I had gained something far better than *Yeti’s Necklace*.

Unaffected by Cold and Heat.

That was why I hadn’t shed a single drop of sweat. It wouldn’t matter if one hour became ten.

This level of heat couldn’t affect me at all.

It would be far better to give the necklace to someone who actually needed it.

“Uncle.”

“Huff, huff. What?”

Im Kkeokjeong, who had been walking a few steps ahead, turned around. Sweat poured from his head as if someone had installed a sprinkler on top of it.

“Why are you sweating so much? Are you all right?”

“…Do I look all right?”

“No.”

“Then don’t talk to me. I’m dying here.”

“You should’ve worn something cooler. Team Leader Choi has plenty of magical Equipment.”

“I thought we were going to fight a Manticore, so I went all in on defense. At this rate, they’ll be holding my funeral.”

“We can’t have that. You have a wife and children.”

I laughed quietly and put the necklace around his neck myself. Im Kkeokjeong’s eyes widened as the cool wind of the snowy plains washed over him.

“Huh? What’s this?”

“A present. Not that I’m giving it to you, of course. I’m only lending it to you while we’re traveling.”

“Whew. I don’t know what this is, but I can finally breathe again.”

Life returned to his exhausted face. Just as Im Kkeokjeong beamed at me—

—Peeeeep!

A piercing shriek rang out from somewhere.

The birds hiding in the dense forest burst into flight, and branches and leaves came crashing down over everyone’s heads like a torrential downpour.

But no one, including me, paid them any attention.

—Kyaaaaaaak!

A bloodcurdling cry rang out as an enormous shadow engulfed all twenty-odd people.

I looked up and spotted a dark shape circling impossibly high overhead.

“Wyvern…”

Won Myunghoon had been wrong.

Not half a day. Not a full day.

After only one hour—

It had appeared.

Chapter 216

The moment I saw the Wyvern circling overhead, only one thought came to mind.

It's small.

It stretched over twenty meters[1158] from head to tail, with a massive body and wings, but it didn't intimidate me in the slightest.

Maybe it was because of the one I'd encountered three years ago.

Is it because I've gotten stronger? No. That thing was much bigger and stronger.

That one had been pitch-black all over. By contrast, the Wyvern circling overhead now had a bright green body.

At the head of the group, Won Myunghoon announced its identity in a powerful voice.

"It's a Green Wyvern! It's a relatively weak specimen, so everyone stay calm!"

A man in his early thirties drove a tower shield into the ground and shouted,

"Form up!"

At the command of Star Guild's second A-Rank Hunter and Team Leader 1, the tanks rushed forward and formed a wall of shields.

"Taekyung, watch yourself!"

Im Kkeokjeong hurriedly called out a warning, then joined the wall of tanks with a spirited yell.

Boom! Boom-boom-boom!

The first row, then the second. Big, beautiful tower shields overlapped in layers, forming a curved defensive barrier.

The mages and healers standing by began chanting their spells.

"Let the wind dwell within you. Haste!"

"Power that shatters stone. Strength!"

"Vitality to the weary flesh. Healing!"

Bright motes of light spread outward like dandelion seeds.

At the same time, a System notification rang out.

Ding.

> **System** - Your physical abilities have temporarily increased due to the effects of magic. - **Agility** has increased by 10! - **Strength** has increased by 10! - Fatigue has been restored!

There was a reason people said mages and healers had iron rice bowls.[1159]

[1158] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

[1159] "Iron rice bowl" is a Korean expression for a secure, dependable job.

The so-called three-drug combo of buff spells was far more effective than I had expected.

Is it because they're all B-Rank?

Every Hunter gathered here was talented enough to be welcomed wherever they went.

But the Green Wyvern circling overhead, watching for an opening, was no easy opponent either.

It was an A-Rank monster, after all.

"Kyaaaaaaak!"

With an earsplitting shriek, it opened its enormous jaws.

The next moment, green slime visible even from a distance poured down like torrential rain.

"It's poison!"

"Scatter!"

Some people ducked behind the tanks' shield wall, while others threw themselves toward nearby cover.

I was one of the latter. The moment I took shelter behind a boulder the size of a house, green rain blanketed everything within a radius of about thirty meters.[1160]

Thut-thut-thut. Ssssss!

Poison. Acidic poison, at that.

The moment it touched the rock, holes riddled its surface, and an indescribable stench stabbed at my nose.

So even a weak Wyvern is still a Wyvern.

A tiger cub was still a tiger.

The Green Wyvern might have been relatively weak for its kind, but it spewed its poison with frightening speed, and the acid was incredibly potent. Any middling or low-rank Hunters would have melted along with their Equipment.

"Team Leader 1. Casualty report."

"None."

Most of the people gathered here were B-Rank Hunters.

Even Im Kkeokjeong, the only real weak link, was a veteran with twenty years of experience.

Team Leader Choi's top-tier Equipment made up for his lacking physical abilities, so no one had suffered any harm.

"As it should be."

Won Myunghoon nodded in satisfaction, but the Green Wyvern was thoroughly enraged.

[1160] Thirty meters is about 98 ft.

“Kyaaak! Kyaaaaaaak!”

It glared at us through vertically slit pupils, then suddenly folded its wings.

Its massive body, which had been cruising leisurely through the sky, tilted toward the ground and began a steep dive.

Whoooooosh!

The sight of the Wyvern plunging from several hundred meters[1161] up brought a crashing airplane to mind.

We could at least block its acidic poison with our shields, but if that thing hit us, we were done for.

Terrified by a situation he had never faced before, Im Kkeokjeong screamed,

“Honey! Jinwoo! Sowon!”

At this rate, he’d start calling out his father’s cousin next.

Unlike Kkeokjeong, however, the Star Guild members remained calm.

Won Myunghoon even flashed me a broad grin.

“Taekyung, want hyung[1162] to show you something cool?”

“…Now?”

“Yeah.”

Wouldn’t it be better to order everyone to scatter?

There were still several dozen seconds before impact, but how could he be this relaxed?

“Watch carefully. It’ll help you.”

After tossing out those words, Won Myunghoon shifted his spear into a reverse grip.

“Hup.”

Veins bulged across his dense muscles, and an immense amount of mana surged into his spear like a rising tide.

At the same time, a faint line of light appeared along the spearhead.

Ssssss.

It was Spear Energy—a powerful concentration of mana known as Aura in the modern world.

“Kyaaaaaau!”

Perhaps it sensed that power. The Green Wyvern roared and twisted its body, aiming directly for Won Myunghoon and me.

And then—

Thud! Boom!

[1161] Several hundred meters is several hundred yards; 300 m is about 980 ft.

[1162] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Won Myunghoon kicked off the ground and charged forward. One step, two, and finally three.

The Green Wyvern, no more than a black speck moments ago, was now only a few meters[1163] above us. Its green eyes, each as large as a basketball, flashed, and its rough-scaled jaws opened wide.

Just as its sharp teeth were about to descend upon its small prey—

“Hah!”

With a powerful shout, light shot from Won Myunghoon’s hand.

Whooooooosh! Crunch!

The Aura-wreathed spear pierced straight through the Green Wyvern’s neck. Red blood and green acidic poison sprayed out like a fountain.

Ssssss!

Its pupils contracted to pinpoints as its flesh burned, and its body, dozens of meters[1164] long, thrashed wildly.

“Kiiiik! Kiiiiiik!”

Boom! Crash-crash!

Rocks and trees shattered and went flying without distinction.

The Green Wyvern’s wings quivered as it writhed in pain.

Only a few seconds later, its rigidly raised tail dropped limply to the ground.

“Kiiiuuu…”

With its dying cry, the light vanished from its savage eyes.

Then, as if to prove its death, a System notification rang out.

Ding.

> **System** - You have defeated **Lv. 97 Green Wyvern**! - No EXP has been awarded because you made no contribution!

Of course. The credit belonged to one person alone.

I dismissed the holographic window and saw Won Myunghoon pulling his spear from the Green Wyvern’s corpse.

“As expected of our Guild Master!”

“A ranker really is on another level. That Aura was incredible!”

“What ranker? That was a long time ago.”

Won Myunghoon grinned at the cheers ringing out from every direction and walked over to me.

“Did you get a good look?”

[1163] A few meters is roughly 7–13 ft.

[1164] Each 10 m is about 33 ft, so dozens of meters span tens or hundreds of feet.

“Uh, yes.”

“That was your first time seeing Aura in person, right?”

“Um… that’s right.”

“Haha. You must’ve been surprised if you’re stammering that badly.”

A gravelly voice suddenly cut in.

“Who wouldn’t be?”

It was Team Leader 1, Star Guild’s second-in-command and the main tank of today’s raid team.

He looked like a weasel. Tapping me lightly on the arm, he continued with a shameless grin.

“When I first saw it, I wondered how something like that could even exist. People don’t say you need to wield Aura to be a true A-Rank Hunter for nothing.”

Won Myunghoon made a show of frowning.

“Quit buttering me up, punk. You’re embarrassing me.”

“Come on, how am I buttering you up? You really are that good. It’s not like I’m making it up. Don’t you agree, Hunter Jin Taekyung?”

“Uh… yes.”

“See? I’m not the only one who thinks so.”

I licked my dry lips, unsure what to say. Fortunately, Won Myunghoon spoke before the mood could turn awkward.

“You’re all right except for all the sucking up. Enough flattery. Have the guys clean this up and inspect the Equipment again.”

“Understood, Guild Master. Loyalty!”

After giving an exaggerated salute, Team Leader 1 turned away.

“That guy’s always been like that. He’s flighty and careless enough to send the wrong contract…”

Won Myunghoon’s voice trailed off as he watched Team Leader 1 walk away.

“But, Taekyung.”

“Yes?”

“Are you all right? What’s with that expression you’ve had this whole time?”

“…It’s nothing. I was just a little surprised.”

“Was it the Wyvern? Well, this is your first A-Rank Gate, so that’s understandable. You’ll get used to it.”

“…”

I swallowed the words that had risen to my throat. I finally understood how the barber who saw the king’s donkey ears must have felt.[1165]

[1165] In a traditional tale, a barber discovers that the king has donkey ears but is forbidden to reveal the secret.

That wasn't what surprised me.

Trying not to show how confused and frustrated I was, I looked at Won Myunghoon.

He was tall and long-limbed, with a youthful face that made it hard to believe he was nearly forty.

But the real reason I had admired him wasn't his handsome appearance or his catchy hit songs.

An A-Rank Hunter. A master of the spear. And a ranker.

For as long as I could remember, my idol hadn't been the celebrity Won Myunghoon, but the Hunter Won Myunghoon.

He was why I had chosen the spear when I became a Hunter. I had read and reread the spear manual he wrote during his ranker days until it fell apart.

But…

Why is he so weak?

The reason I had stood still from beginning to end was simple.

I wanted to witness Won Myunghoon fight with my own eyes.

What I saw went beyond anything I could have imagined—in an entirely different sense.

His movements are slow as hell, everything he does is needlessly flashy, and he can't even use Aura properly.

Watching him had nearly given me a stroke.

Had Won Myunghoon always been this weak? Or had his skills declined?

My head was full of questions, but if I had to sum up my thoughts in a single line, it would be this:

What the fuck is this?

It was unfair. There was no particular reason for me to feel wronged, but somehow I felt spectacularly cheated!

It was like reserving a full-course meal at a seven-star hotel only to be served braised boneless pollock and beef bibim sauce.[1166]

This isn't what I had in mind. It really isn't.

Oblivious to my feelings, Won Myunghoon still wore a relaxed, confident smile.

"By the way, where's the necklace? I don't see it."

Was the necklace really the issue right now?

Overcome by an inexplicable sense of emptiness, I answered carelessly.

"…I put it in my pants pocket."

"Why?"

"Just because. It was getting in the way. Why?"

[1166] *Bibim* means "mixed"; bibim sauce is a seasoned sauce used to mix with food, commonly rice.

“No reason. It doesn’t matter as long as you keep it safe.”

Won Myunghoon’s gaze flicked toward my lower body. After confirming the bulge in the pocket of my tight leather pants, he added,

“Whatever you do, don’t lose it. Got it?”

“Yes.”

There was no way I could lose it. No—if I ever did, I’d have no reason to go on living.

My stuff is precious.

It really was a good thing that my body in the Murim and my body in reality were the same.

Thinking of the black anaconda coiled inside my pants lifted my gloomy mood a little.

While the Hunters dismantled the Green Wyvern and cleaned up the area, Won Myunghoon and Team Leader 1 moved to a secluded spot.

“That necklace works well.”

Team Leader 1 grinned.

“It wasn’t easy to get. Even magical scans can’t detect it.”

“Yeah, you did well, but…”

Won Myunghoon suddenly furrowed his brow and continued.

“It’s more effective than I expected. We haven’t even left the jungle yet, and a Wyvern has already appeared.”

“Couldn’t it just be a coincidence? It’s not that rare.”

“It was a coincidence eight years ago, too.”

“…What choice do we have? You can’t predict what’ll happen next inside a Gate.”

“That’s why I hate Gates. With people, you can more or less figure out what the bastard is thinking. But with this fucked-up place, you can’t.”

Won Myunghoon answered in a low voice and looked around.

Everywhere he looked, there was nothing but grass, trees, and strange insects. He wanted to return to the forest of skyscrapers as soon as possible.

“Let’s get started soon. Something bigger and stronger than a Green Wyvern needs to show up.”

“So the surviving witnesses can testify?”

“You’re one smart bastard. I tell you one thing, and you figure out ten.”

A smile formed on Won Myunghoon’s lips.

Chapter 217

Bean sprout soup might not look like much, but it contains more ingredients than you'd think.

In that sense, *The Black Wyvern's Nest* was like bean sprout soup.

This vast A-Rank Gate was home to more than just Wyverns. All kinds of monsters lived here, like the ingredients that went into bean sprout soup.

—Kweeeek!

At the faint sound of a pig squealing in the distance, I muttered, "…Does bean sprout soup have pork in it?"

Won Myunghoon, who was walking beside me, turned his head.

"Hm? Why are you suddenly talking about pork?"

"It's nothing. I thought there might be a monster nearby."

"A monster?"

Won Myunghoon stopped and listened for a moment.

"I don't hear anything."

"Uh, well…"

How was I supposed to explain this? As I pondered what to say, Won Myunghoon smiled.

"Haha, you must be tense. Don't get scared just because this is an A-Rank Gate. Relax."

"I definitely heard something…"

"You must have imagined it. If there'd been a sound like that, I would've noticed it first."

Faced with his confident tone and smile, I kept my mouth shut.

Won Myunghoon was a famous star, but his reputation as a Hunter was considerable too.

Being a ranker meant placing among the top one hundred out of the tens of thousands of Hunters in Korea.

Compared to him, I was still just a rookie who had only recently begun to stand out.

On the surface, anyway.

There probably wasn't anyone else in the entire world with as many secrets as I had.

But people saw only what was in front of them and heard only what they wanted to hear.

I swallowed the words that had risen to my throat and nodded.

"I guess I imagined it."

"That happens. It's good to stay alert, but don't worry too much. We're using detection magic as we go, anyway."

"…"

I stared at Won Myunghoon as he gave my shoulder a knowing pat.

Watching him had left me with a complicated feeling for a while now. How should I put it?

Was this really all there was to him?

A few hours earlier, while watching Won Myunghoon fight the Green Wyvern, I had realized two things.

First, Wyverns weren't as strong as I'd expected. And second—

Neither is Myunghoon hyung[1167]*.*

He was strong. There was no doubt about that. He could wield Aura, and he had once been skilled enough to become a ranker.

By Murim standards, you could reasonably call him a Peak master.

But that was as far as it went. No—if what Won Myunghoon had shown was the full extent of his ability, he was actually inferior to a Peak master from the Murim.

He doesn't know how to use his strength properly.

Was it because the environments were different?

Unlike the modern world, the Murim was a brutal place where people had to survive with nothing but a weapon in their hands.

In a world where the sword was closer than the law, martial arts had inevitably been developed to the extreme.

Modern Hunters, on the other hand, focus on raids. And they have magic.

Martial artists constantly honed themselves within the vast discipline of martial arts, while Hunters divided up their roles and pursued maximum efficiency within them.

Neither approach was inherently right or wrong, but one thing was certain.

When it comes to individual combat ability, Hunters are no match for martial artists.

If what he had shown so far was everything he could do, Won Myunghoon was no exception.

The fact that he could wield Aura made no difference.

I really have grown stronger.

It had only been a few months.

Yet I had grown enough to judge an A-Rank Hunter who had been my idol for years.

I'm happy about it, but it's bittersweet too.

I was still gazing at Won Myunghoon with mixed feelings when—

[1167] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

—Kweeeek!

—Chweek!

The second set of cries was louder and clearer than the first.

Won Myunghoon finally noticed them too. He turned his head and began searching for their source.

“Where the hell did that come from…?”

I pulled the spear from my back and answered, “Five o’clock. About thirty jang[1168] away—or rather, a hundred meters[1169].”

“Huh?”

“There are quite a few of them. You should start preparing for the raid.”

“G-Get ready?”

“Yes. Sounds like forty or fifty.”

“What are you—”

Won Myunghoon couldn’t finish.

We had spotted a group of more than forty Orcs approaching through the dense undergrowth.

“Forty-seven. Should I take care of them?”

“…”

“Hyung[1170]?”

At my call, Won Myunghoon jolted as if waking from sleep.

“Uh, huh?”

“Should I take care of them?”

“…By yourself?”

“Yes. I haven’t warmed up yet.”

“R-right. Do whatever you want.”

“If any of them try to run, please deal with them.”

I finished speaking, swung the spear shaft around a few times, and walked toward them.

It was an ordinary iron spear of the sort you could find anywhere, without a single magical enchantment.

If I use enchanted Equipment for no reason, I’ll have trouble adapting in the Murim.

Magic was astonishingly convenient and useful.

It might help me right away, but in the long run, relying on it would do more harm than good.

[1168] *Jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty jang is about 90.9 m (298 ft).

[1169] A hundred meters is about 328 ft.

[1170] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

I needed to improve my fundamental skills instead of depending on Equipment if I wanted to handle any crisis that came my way.

If I take down all of them, maybe I'll level up once.

With that happy thought, I kicked off the ground. The wind split around me, whipping through my hair.

Whoooosh!

Whoosh! Slice! Thud-thud-thud!

The spearhead sliced cleanly through an Orc's throat.

Before its knees even touched the ground, the head of the Orc beside it exploded.

Then another. Two more. Three after that…

Every time a silver streak carved through the air, blood and death followed.

He tore through their ranks unhindered.

"…Wow."

Team Leader 1 let out an involuntary gasp, then hurriedly closed his mouth. Won Myunghoon was glaring at him with murder in his eyes.

"Uh, Guild Master. I didn't mean—"

"You bastard. Is this really the time to stand around enjoying the show?"

"I'm sorry. It just slipped out…"

Team Leader 1 cautiously studied Won Myunghoon's expression before continuing.

"No, but he really is good, isn't he?"

"…What do you mean, good?"

"Just look at how he moves. He's no ordinary A-Rank rookie."

"…"

"He doesn't seem to be wearing a single piece of magical Equipment, either. You have to give him credit just for having the guts to charge fifty Orcs alone. If someone told me to do that… honestly, I wouldn't be confident."

Won Myunghoon licked his lips, his face tight with irritation.

He couldn't deny anything Team Leader 1 had said. Every last word of it was true.

The longer he watched Jin Taekyung, the more bewildered he became.

What the hell is that guy?

Orcs might be treated like punching bags in fantasy novels, but they were by no means easy monsters.

There were many different species of Orcs and dozens of confirmed tribes. Judging by the crude armor these ones wore, they were B-Rank Orc Warriors.

And yet Jin Taekyung was overwhelming them.

He's taking on fifty Orc Warriors alone? A brat who only just awakened as an A-Rank?

Won Myunghoon had already investigated him thoroughly.

Jin Taekyung had been a bottom-tier Hunter branded as defective, someone who had started as an F-Rank and was certain to die as an F-Rank.

How could a man who had spent his time fighting goblins in tiny F-Rank Gates do this?

"Guild Master. Guild Master?"

Won Myunghoon snapped out of his thoughts and answered dryly.

"What?"

"Didn't you hear me? I've been asking whether you noticed anything suspicious. You've been beside him this whole time."

"Suspicious?"

"Yes. It's strange. That Jin Taekyung bastard definitely has something going on."

"…"

After a brief silence, Won Myunghoon gave Team Leader 1 a quick account of what had just happened.

"He knew the Orcs were coming?"

"Keep your voice down. We're not the only ones here."

Team Leader 1 glanced behind him. After checking the Peace Guild members watching the battle with peaceful expressions, as if they had come out for a picnic, he whispered in a voice barely louder than an ant.

"My God. How did that bastard know? Do you have any idea?"

"It must have been detection magic. It had to be detection magic."

"What if it wasn't detection magic?"

"What?"

Team Leader 1 swallowed hard.

"Guild Master, what if—and this really is just a one-in-a-million possibility…"

"Shut your mouth. I'm not listening to that bullshit."

"W-we can't rule it out."

A dangerous light flashed in Won Myunghoon's eyes.

"Fuck… Are you saying that bastard Jin Taekyung is stronger than me? Is that what you're trying to say?"

Overwhelmed by his murderous aura, Team Leader 1 hastily lowered his head.

But Won Myunghoon's low growl continued to bore into his ears.

[1171] *Go-Stop* is a Korean card game played with flower cards.

"You think I learned Aura by playing Go-Stop[1171]? I took in a bastard who had nothing and raised him, and now you think I'm a joke? Does the title of ranker look like a fucking joke to you?"

"N-no, sir."

At least get your facts straight. When we first met, you and I were about the same. And you only became a ranker because of the fame you built in the entertainment industry and all that lobbying.

Team Leader 1 swallowed the words threatening to spill out.

They had been together for well over ten years. Too much had happened between them to turn back now.

Sensing his resentment, Won Myunghoon glared at him like a venomous snake.

"Our Jonghun's all grown up."

Calling him by name rather than title meant something very different.

Several Star Guild members sensed the tension and moved around the two men with practiced ease, blocking them from outsiders' view.

"Hey, Kim Jonghun."

Tap, tap.

Won Myunghoon lightly patted Team Leader 1's cheek and muttered in a voice drier than sand, "Get a grip. If you make a mistake here, we're all fucked."

"…Yes, sir."

"Send a few agile guys to find the boss monster. If that doesn't work, drag over a few Wyverns that look strong enough."

"Understood."

The moment Team Leader 1 answered with a cowed expression, cheers erupted from somewhere.

A middle-aged man with a bandit's beard was jumping up and down like a live fish.

"Taekyung! You bastard! You magnificent bastard!"

The battle was finally over.

It had taken only about fifteen minutes to wipe out nearly fifty B-Rank Orc Warriors.

Amid the dozens of corpses strewn across the ground, a handsome young man with bold features grinned.

"Ah, now I'm finally warmed up. Myunghoon hyung[1172], I did well, right?"

"…!"

Won Myunghoon hurriedly turned away to hide the hideous scowl that had twisted his face.

[1172] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

Goddammit…!

Every time he looked at Jin Taekyung, his head burned and his stomach churned.

The bastard had only attracted the media's attention through sheer luck. He had been handed such a golden opportunity, yet he neither knew how to use his fame nor had any intention of doing so.

To Won Myunghoon, it was all an act—and the source of his disgust.

You're going to spend your whole life running Gates until you drop dead, yet you don't even know your place and still have the nerve to reject my offer?

If Jin Taekyung had wanted to become a star Hunter under another major entertainment agency, Won Myunghoon wouldn't have been this angry.

But Taekyung had rejected him without the slightest hesitation. He had chosen the Peace Guild, little more than a mom-and-pop operation.

Fucking idiot.

He would regret it.

Won Myunghoon muttered those words inwardly and signaled Team Leader 1 with his eyes.

"Great job! Great job, you bastard!"

Thump! Thump!

Im Kkeokjeong snorted excitedly as he pounded me on the shoulder.

"Wow! Fifty Orc Warriors! You really are the greatest Hunter!"

"Calm down."

"Your movement, your spearmanship, your soul… Just what I'd expect from an A-Rank Hunter. You turned this Gate upside down!"

"…"

Why was "soul" in there? And what exactly had I turned upside down?

Unlike me, who was dumbfounded, Im Kkeokjeong showed no sign of calming down.

"I knew you'd become someone like this. Ahem."

"…You aren't crying, are you?"

Unable to continue, Im Kkeokjeong's lips trembled, and he turned his head away.

"Who's crying? I just… I was remembering the old days."

"Uncle."

"Do you remember that time two years ago when we were ambushed in an E-Rank Gate?"

"When…? Oh, right."

“Yeah. That bastard of a Team Leader was the first to run, and I thought we were all going to die. But you stayed at the rear until the very end and protected the wounded.”

“Was Uncle one of them?”

Im Kkeokjeong nodded, his face full of emotion.

As far as I remembered, I had saved about seven people that day. It wasn’t until now that I learned Im Kkeokjeong had been one of them.

Was that why he recommended me to Team Leader Choi?

“You still remember that?”

“I might forget a wrong done to me, but I’ll never forget a debt for as long as I live.”

“Forget it. It’s all in the past.”

“Anyway, I’m glad to see you doing so well, Taekyung. No matter how hard I try, I’ll never be more than a D-Rank Hunter… but just remember that I’ll always be rooting for you.”

I knew.

It wasn’t just Im Kkeokjeong. The other Guild members had always cared about me too.

I guess I’m lucky when it comes to people.

I looked warmly at the Guild members.

First was Team Leader Choi, our main source of funding.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Yes, Team Leader.”

“You truly are remarkable.”

“It was nothing.”

“Your discerning eye is remarkable.”

“…?”

“That look in your eyes just now must mean you recognized this *Frozen Eye* around my neck.”

Team Leader Choi smiled proudly and pulled off the necklace.

When did he even put that on? I’d never seen it before today.

“Russia’s foremost jewelry maker, Vladimir Stalin, designed it…”

“…”

Fuck. Give me back my touching moment.

I was sighing at his maddening consistency when—

“Hm?”

Team Leader Choi suddenly froze and pointed at Im Kkeokjeong’s neck.

“Is that perhaps Yeti’s Necklace?”

Startled by his greedy stare, Im Kkeokjeong nodded.

“Huh? Uh, yeah.”

“That’s an item that rarely even appears on secondhand markets… Where did you get it?”

“T-this?”

He looked ready to rip off the necklace along with Im Kkeokjeong’s neck.

Sensing a threat to his life, the middle-aged man hurriedly took it off and handed it to me.

“It’s not mine. Taekyung lent it to me.”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung did?”

I nodded.

“I lent it to him. I borrowed it from Myunghoon hyung[1173], though.”

“I see. If you don’t mind, may I examine it for a moment?”

“Well, I don’t see any harm in looking.”

Just as I was about to hand him *Yeti’s Necklace*, curiosity struck me.

Is this thing really that expensive?

Come to think of it, I haven’t even had it appraised yet.

It wasn’t particularly useful to me, but there was no harm in finding out exactly what it did.

Without giving it much thought, I muttered inwardly.

Item Appraisal.

Ding.

[1173] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

Chapter 218

"This is…"

After examining *Yeti's Necklace* for a long moment, Team Leader Choi's eyelids began to tremble.

"I'm angry."

He rarely showed his emotions this openly.

Im Kkeokjeong, who had been squatting quietly, asked with intense curiosity,

"Team Leader Choi, what's wrong? Is there a problem?"

"There is. A very serious problem."

Team Leader Choi bit down hard on his lip and continued.

"The supply of this beautiful product is far too limited. That is the greatest problem of all—one that deserves condemnation from people around the world."

"…Ah."

"Just look at it. The artistry of this icicle design! The magical properties that preserve the very chill of the snowy plains!"

Like a North Korean TV announcer passionately praising the Supreme Leader—no, the necklace—Team Leader Choi whipped his head toward me.

"What do you think, Mr. Jin Taekyung?"

"Me?"

Where should I start? How should I put it? What was I even supposed to say?

My hesitation was brief. A voice came from my mouth, calm and gentle enough to surprise even me.

"I'm angry too."

"…"

"What's wrong?"

"No, it's nothing."

Team Leader Choi gave me a strange look before continuing.

"You just seem a little… unfamiliar somehow."

"Do I?"

I rubbed my chin. The stubble beginning to poke through felt rough against my fingers. Even the sensation felt unfamiliar, almost like touching someone else's skin.

"Is it because I haven't shaved?"

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, could it be…"

Just as Team Leader Choi was about to say something, Won Myunghoon approached with a genial smile.

"Wow, that was incredible. Taekyung, you really can fight."

"…You think so?"

"Your spearmanship was completely different from the manual I wrote. Did you learn it at the training center?"

"No. I just picked up a few things here and there."

"Here and there? That was way beyond anything you could pick up casually. At this rate, you might catch up to me in a few years. Haha."

I silently raised the corners of my mouth.

When nobody joined in, his laughter slowly died away. It should have been awkward, but Won Myunghoon changed the subject without missing a beat.

The entire sequence was polished and seamless, like a scene from a TV drama.

"So, what were you doing?"

His mouth was asking the question, but his eyes were already busy taking stock of the situation. His gaze flicked across *Yeti's Necklace* in Team Leader Choi's hand.

"We were looking at the necklace you lent me. Team Leader Choi is really interested in this kind of thing."

"Team Leader Choi is? Well, I suppose that makes sense. He did seem like the type."

If Won Myunghoon wrapped himself from head to toe in flashy luxury brands, Team Leader Choi was the exact opposite.

Everything he wore was still expensive, but how should I put it? Refined and understated. Either way, anyone who saw how he normally dressed could tell he had an eye for such things.

But Won Myunghoon's attention lay elsewhere.

"So, what did you think after seeing it in person?"

"It's much better in person. If you ever decide to sell it, please contact me."

"I'm afraid that won't happen. I treasure it a great deal."

Something he treasures…

I mulled over his words, then abruptly spoke.

"It must be important."

"Of course. Very important."

"I see."

I held *Yeti's Necklace* out to Won Myunghoon.

"I'll give it back now."

"Hm?"

"You said it was important to you, hyung.[1174] And judging by what Team Leader Choi said, it sounds extremely expensive too."

"…"

[1174] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"Aren't you going to take it?"

The necklace swayed in my hand with a metallic clatter.

A brief silence passed. Won Myunghoon gazed at me, and a faint smile appeared on his lips.

"Taekyung."

"Yes."

"Your hyung[1175] values the bonds between people more than material things."

"The bonds between people."

"That's right. The same goes for the Guild members who came with us today. They stayed by my side through the hardest time of my life."

"You mean eight years ago?"

"…Well, yes. Anyway, what I'm trying to say is, don't worry about it too much. What's so precious about a necklace like that? Right?"

Won Myunghoon patted my shoulder with his broad palm. Unlike mine, his palm was soft, and his fingernails were long.

A thought suddenly occurred to me.

Maybe this person standing in front of me isn't the person I knew.

"Actually, the necklace is a gift."

"A gift?"

"Yeah. A gift from your hyung[1176] to you."

Every time Won Myunghoon leaned closer, the strong scent of his cologne washed over me.

"So don't give it to anyone else. Got it?"

"…"

"Taekyung?"

I put the necklace around my neck as I answered.

"Yes. I won't let anyone else touch it."

Ding.

> **System** - You have equipped **Yeti's Necklace**. - The wind of the snowfield flows from the necklace.

As the wind of the snowfield wrapped around my entire body, I recalled the Item Window I had seen just five minutes earlier.

[1175] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[1176] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Yeti's Necklace
Type: Accessory
Grade: Peak
Restriction: None
Description: A necklace that only an exceptionally skilled Yeti warrior may possess. In truth, however, it is a shackle proving that its wearer was once enslaved by the dragonkin and raised as livestock for food. Anyone who possesses this item becomes a target of dragonkin monsters, regardless of species.
Effect: Wind of the Snowfield effect activated.

So I'm a target.

It was hardly a pleasant word.

In more ways than one.

Time passed slowly inside the Gate.

After half a day of travel, we finally left the jungle and entered the wasteland. Yet the only monsters we had encountered so far were the Green Wyvern that had appeared at the beginning, the pack of Orcs I had dealt with, and the Trolls the others were fighting now.

—Gwoooor!

The Troll stood about a head taller than an adult man and had an abnormally large head.

Trolls were monsters with extraordinary regenerative abilities. That was also why they cropped up everywhere as the main ingredient in healing potions.

They could regrow severed arms and legs in a matter of seconds, which naturally made them difficult opponents.

But the Star Guild members were seasoned veterans in their own right.

"The head! Aim for the head!"

"Fire magic!"

Sshhk! Fwoooosh!

In the early days of the Great Cataclysm, Trolls had earned a fearsome reputation as immortal monsters, but their weaknesses had soon been exposed.

The head and the heart. And magic on top of that.

Unless it was an undead monster, death after the cessation of breathing was only natural.

Trolls possessed enough terrifying regenerative power to restore even their heads and hearts, but that didn't make them truly immortal.

Freeze them with ice or sear them with flames before they could regenerate, and there was little they could do.

"Damage dealers, get in there and carve it up!"

"Mages, stand by!"

Sshh-shh-shhk! Thwack!

—Graaaar!

The Troll toppled backward after losing an arm and a leg.

A moment later, the keen axe blade of a halberd cleaved through the thick fat and muscle of its neck.

Thud! Sshhk!

The Troll's body flailed, now empty above the shoulders. Soon, new flesh began to writhe and swell across the cut surface.

In a little over a minute, it would have a new neck.

Of course, the Star Guild members had no intention of waiting that long.

"Burn it!"

Fwoooosh! Ssssss!

Bone-chilling cold and skin-scorching flames struck the body.

Unable to regenerate, the Troll shuddered violently once, then fell still.

"Unit Three clear!"

"Help over here! This one's regenerating!"

With three Hunters assigned to each Troll, the battle ended quickly.

Amid the stench of burning flesh and fat, Won Myunghoon watched from a dozen or so meters[1177] away and muttered under his breath.

His voice was so quiet that nobody could make it out over the noise of battle, but to me, it sounded as clear as if he were speaking right beside me.

"Idiots had to stink up the place. I told them to freeze them whenever possible."

"Hah."

I barely managed to suppress the hollow laugh trying to escape.

Someone once said that life was a tragedy up close and a comedy from a distance.

But a battle against monsters was a tragedy no matter where you watched it from.

When you could lose your life in an instant, the smell of burning Troll flesh was nothing.

[1177] A dozen or so meters is roughly 39 ft.

It's a hundred times better than lying behind a folding screen, smelling your own funeral incense.

But to Won Myunghoon, it was someone else's problem.

He was frowning and cursing under his breath when he suddenly sensed my gaze and turned toward me.

"Oh, Taekyung."

His voice was warm, and his forehead had smoothed out as if nothing had happened.

Everything about him was natural.

That only made it feel even more unnatural.

"What is it? Do you have something to say?"

For some reason, it sounded like he was really asking, *Did you hear everything I said?*

I kept my face blank and answered casually.

"Yes."

"Really? What is it?"

"I feel a little nauseous. I was fine at first, but… I've felt strange ever since we entered the Gate. I even tried healing magic, but it didn't help much."

"Ah. That."

Won Myunghoon let out a quiet laugh.

"It's because this is your first A-Rank Gate. The amount of magical power distributed inside a Gate is on an entirely different level."

"Oh, I see."

"Beginners are all like that. I'm used to it by now."

I let out an exclamation as if I were hearing this for the first time, even though I already knew everything.

"So I'll get used to it next time too, right?"

"Next time?"

The corners of Won Myunghoon's mouth twitched before he nodded.

"That's right. You'll be much more used to it next time."

"I hope I can come with you again then, hyung.[1178]"

"Well, I don't know when I'll have time. My schedule is packed."

"You don't even have time for raids?"

"You may not know this yet, Taekyung, but Guild Masters like me are always busy. We have to coordinate the entire Guild."

"Ah."

[1178] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"It's the difference between a musician and a conductor. You know what a maestro is, right?"

As Won Myunghoon mimed waving a conductor's baton, I abruptly asked, "Then did you go to the department store for a Guild-related meeting?"

"Hm?"

"I saw an article about it online. What was the headline again? Ah, I remember."

Won Myunghoon suddenly lost his words. Watching him, I continued clearly,

"Something like *Rising Star Hunter Won Myunghoon Sweeps Up Luxury Goods.*"

"Was there an article like that?"

"It was on a Hunter community site for a little while. It got deleted after five minutes."

"R-really? Are you sure you didn't misread it?"

"Yes. There's a Rice Weevil[1179] who doesn't study these days and does nothing but scour the Internet. He lets me know the moment an article appears."

A deep dimple formed in Won Myunghoon's handsome face. But this wasn't the bright smile I remembered seeing on television.

"That can't be right."

"Isn't it?"

"Of course not. I do like shopping, but I'm not that bad. At most, I might go once a month."

"I heard pictures were uploaded too."

"…"

"You know Dispass, right? The site that specializes in digging up dirt on celebrities. They even interviewed someone from the department store. Apparently, you're a VVIP who visits five times a week."

"…"

Won Myunghoon licked his dry lips. The dimple had vanished without a trace.

"Taekyung. You don't actually believe that, do you?"

"Come on, it must be a rumor sheet. You're busy coordinating the Guild schedule, hyung.[1180] Maestro."

"…Yes, Maestro."

I vigorously mimed waving a conductor's baton while Won Myunghoon stared at me with dry eyes.

That was when—

"Hyung![1181] No, CEO!"

[1179] "Rice weevil" (*ssalbeolle*) is Korean slang for a freeloader who eats without contributing anything.

[1180] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[1181] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

The shout rang out across the endless wasteland of dirt, sand, and winding rocky hills. It had come from Star Guild's Team Leader 1.

He had gone scouting in search of the Wyvern that had been nowhere in sight, and now he was back.

But unlike when he had set out at a leisurely pace, he was sprinting toward us like a madman, his face deathly pale.

"What happened? Where are the others?"

At Won Myunghoon's question, Team Leader 1 stammered.

"Th-that, th-that…"

I didn't need to hear the rest.

Seven people had left, but only one had returned. The drops of blood splashed across his face and armor turned my guess into certainty.

"You bastard. Spit it out!"

Team Leader 1 flinched at the thunderous roar.

"We found the Wyvern. We found it."

"The Wyvern? How many?"

"O-one."

"What? One?"

An A-Rank Hunter and six B-Rank Hunters made a formation more than capable of dealing with a single Wyvern.

And yet six people had died, while one had fled back alone.

"Is that supposed to be an explanation? Are you messing with me?"

"They're all dead. We approached while using concealment magic, but… it noticed us."

"What kind of bullshit is that? How could a Wyvern see through concealment magic?"

Click. Clack-clack.

His teeth chattering from fear, Team Leader 1 finally forced out a single word.

"A-A Named Monster."

"…"

"It's definitely a Named Monster. This place… it's a Mutated Gate."

An A-Rank Mutated Gate.

And a Named Monster.

There was no one among us who didn't understand what those two words meant.

Amid the suffocating silence, someone muttered in a voice barely loud enough to hear.

"Fuck…"

Chapter 219

From the early days of the Great Cataclysm to the present, humanity had drawn on countless experiences of death and destruction to classify monsters and establish a hierarchy among them.

Accordingly, the Grade of each Gate was determined by the Grade of the monsters inhabiting it.

However…

There are exceptions to every rule.

Mutated Gates were one such exception. They existed outside the boundaries humanity had established. They were, in every sense of the word, mutations.

Gates were already an enigma to humanity, and now another variable had entered the equation.

The worst kind.

A D-Rank monster could appear in an F-Rank Gate. A B-Rank monster could appear in a D-Rank Gate.

That alone was the stuff of nightmares, but an even greater problem remained.

Rare Monsters.

As if running into an unexpected higher-level monster wasn't bad enough, every one of those creatures possessed strength that surpassed that of other monsters of the same Grade.

That was when the term Rare Monster was first coined.

Before long, someone raised another question.

Then what about the Rare Monsters that appear in A-Rank Mutated Gates? Aren't they too strong to be considered the same Grade?

For Hunters, A-Rank was the highest level attainable through a single awakening.

Those acknowledged as particularly strong even among A-Rank Hunters received the prestigious Title of ranker.

The same issue applied to monsters. After endless debate within the relevant academic circles, a new term was born.

Named Monster.

True monstrosities that had transcended the limits of A-Rank.

Team Leader 1, the only one to return alive, had said that such a Named Monster was here.

Right where we stood, in the Wyvern's Nest.

"Bullshit!"

Won Myunghoon seized Team Leader 1 by the collar with a furious shout.

"A Named Monster? There's no way something like that could be here."

“I-I’m telling the truth. I saw it clearly with my own eyes.”

Team Leader 1 continued in a trembling voice.

“It was several times larger than an ordinary Wyvern. I could hardly believe it even while I was looking right at it.”

“Shut up!”

But the terror the Named Monster had instilled in Team Leader 1 was beyond anything I could have imagined.

The title of A-Rank Hunter seemed wasted on him. He was as terrified as a seven-year-old child.

“That thing is on a completely different level from any Wyvern we’ve faced before. We need to run. Right now.”

“Kim Jonghun, you son of a…”

Grind.

Won Myunghoon ground his teeth, but that was all he did.

He might have fallen short of my expectations in every possible way, but he was still an A-Rank Hunter who had once risen to the ranks of the rankers. There was no way he didn’t understand what everyone else here already knew.

Won Myunghoon was berating Team Leader 1 merely to hide his own fear.

There must have been signs that this was a Mutated Gate.

I knew them well. I had experienced them myself three years ago.

Strangely few monsters. And far more Magic Gems than the number of defeated monsters should have yielded.

I hadn’t known about the latter. The Star Guild was responsible for handling the spoils, and although this was a joint raid, Won Myunghoon was still the commander with final say over everything.

And that commander just shit the bed.

This was no minor error in judgment.

The creature stalking us somewhere in the wasteland wasn’t an ordinary Wyvern. It was a Named Monster.

“Fucking hell…”

As Won Myunghoon spat out the curse, Team Leader Choi spoke.

“Calm down. Our priority right now should be to withdraw immediately.”

“Calm down? Do I look like I can calm down in a situation like this?”

“I’m telling you to compose yourself and face reality.”

Team Leader Choi continued in the same measured voice.

“Fortunately, it isn’t too late. If we turn back and retrace our route as quickly as possible, we can reach the jungle within an hour. But if we encounter that thing out here in the wasteland…”

“You think I don’t know that? Stop meddling.”

The cheerful, courteous gentleman was gone. Team Leader Choi's gaze cooled at Won Myunghoon's irritable response.

"That's unfortunate. I didn't expect you to take it that way."

"Unfortunate? Just because we're cooperating, you seem to think we're really equals or something… Fuck, there's no point in talking. Anyway, stop telling me what to do. I'm already in a shitty mood."

They said a crisis revealed a person's true nature.

If that was true, this was all there was to Won Myunghoon. The bitter part was knowing I had once idolized someone like him.

Won Myunghoon turned to the Guild members, his face tense with anxiety.

"Take only the Magic Gems. We're heading back to the Gate entrance as fast as possible."

There were two ways out of a Gate: the entrance we had used to come in, and the exit that opened once the boss monster was killed.

Under the circumstances, the former was obviously the right choice.

"Yes, sir."

The preparations were completed quickly. The only problem was Team Leader 1, who remained deathly pale.

"What's wrong with that guy?"

Butler Kim, who had stayed one step behind me and kept quiet the entire time, answered my mutter.

"He's been exposed to a monster's Fear."

"An A-Rank Hunter?"

"The opponent is a Named Monster."

"Oh."

"And a Grade is merely a measure of strength. It has nothing to do with how strong someone's mental fortitude is."

Even so, an A-Rank Hunter had succumbed to Fear.

That left two possibilities. Either Team Leader 1 was weak-willed to begin with, or the Named Monster was simply that powerful.

Personally, I'd prefer the former.

With that thought, I approached Team Leader 1. I only meant to help him up, but he recoiled as if he'd been burned.

"It's okay. I'm not trying to hurt you. You know me, right?"

"J-Jin Taekyung."

"You're still lucid, at least. Now pull yourself together and get up. Unless you'd rather keep sitting there until you become its prey."

"Gah!"

Sometimes it was better to stoke someone's fear than inspire courage.

The word *prey* sent Team Leader 1 shooting to his feet. He glanced around anxiously.

“Th-that thing…?”

“It isn’t here. More importantly, how did you make it back alive?”

I had wanted to ask him that for a while. No one else had thought to once the words *Named Monster* came out.

Team Leader 1 chewed on his lip.

“I had no choice.”

“…I see.”

He had run away. He had abandoned his team members.

But I didn’t condemn him. Not because I understood, but because I didn’t think I had the right.

Someone else can curse him out, but not me.

Whether he knew what I was thinking or not, Team Leader 1 began rambling incoherently.

“We were approaching carefully, but it saw us. Then it spread its wings—its black wings—wide…”

“Black wings?”

“Y-yes. It was black all over, from its head to the tip of its tail.”

A memory suddenly surfaced.

The screams that had filled the cave. Those enormous wings.

The Wyvern I had encountered back then had also been entirely black.

“A Black Wyvern.”

“No, it was different. It was several times larger and stronger than the Black Wyverns we’ve seen so far. That thing… it’s a real monster.”

Then it couldn’t have been the same creature I’d encountered three years ago.

After the Sangdong Station Mutated Gate incident, I had been subjected to countless investigations. The team dispatched to investigate the truth behind the incident had concluded that the creature didn’t fall far outside the normal range for a Black Wyvern.

Then where is it now?

Monsters inside Gates respawned at regular intervals. By the time the investigators arrived, it had already disappeared.

Whenever I drank, I sometimes found myself wondering.

Where is it now? Did another Hunter kill it? If it’s still alive, will I ever get the chance to take revenge?

Now it’s possible.

As long as we were both alive, the day would eventually come when we met again.

I had left it with an indelible memory, and it had done the same to me.

But apparently, that day wasn’t today.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Taekyung!”

The Guild members had finished preparing and were waiting for me. I had just started toward the formation when—

“One eye.”

The single word that suddenly came from Team Leader 1’s mouth made my body freeze.

I slowly turned around. Team Leader 1 pointed to one of his own eyes with a trembling hand.

“What did you just say?”

“That’s right. One of its eyes was ruined. Like something had stabbed it…”

“…!”

A current ran down my spine. My mind went blank, and my fist clenched on its own.

Three years ago, I had charged at that creature prepared to die.

I had gathered every last ounce of strength and unleashed One Annihilation—no, *Stab with All My Strength*. The spearhead had buried itself squarely in its eye.

That had been my final act of defiance, and the only mark I’d managed to leave on it.

It’s that bastard.

I didn’t stop to wonder how an ordinary Black Wyvern had become a Named Monster.

Every hair standing on end across my skin bore witness, and my pounding heart served as both prosecutor and judge.

Everything that made me who I was cried out with one voice.

The unidentified Named Monster Team Leader 1 had described was the very creature that had left me with an indelible nightmare three years ago.

We finally meet again.

I didn’t know what to call this feeling.

Fear? Joy?

My whole body trembled with an emotion I couldn’t name.

My senses were drawn tighter and sharper than ever when the thick scent of blood drifted into them.

—Kyaaaaaaaah!

I raised my head at the roar echoing from the distance.

On the horizon of the wasteland beneath the setting sun, a pair of pitch-black wings was flying toward us.

Goddammit. Goddammit. Goddammit!

The same curses kept replaying endlessly in Won Myunghoon's mind.

His plan was as good as ruined. Now he even had to worry about getting out alive.

A Named Monster.

This was as serious as the situation eight years ago—no, it was even worse.

Won Myunghoon had hurried the Guild members through their preparations and was just about to order them to move out when—

"It's coming."

The low voice piercing his ears made his heart plummet.

All the more so because it belonged to Jin Taekyung.

"W-what do you mean?"

"Prepare for battle. Or run for your life."

"I'm asking what the hell you mean!"

"What else could I mean?"

There was something unfamiliar about Jin Taekyung's dark, steady gaze.

The man before Won Myunghoon now was neither his rabid fan nor the foolish kid in his twenties who had grinned at him like an idiot.

What is this feeling?

As Won Myunghoon flinched, a dry voice slipped between Jin Taekyung's lips.

"Take everyone with you. I still have the necklace."

"…What?"

What the hell was this bastard talking about?

As Won Myunghoon stared at him in confusion, one corner of Jin Taekyung's mouth curled upward.

"Why are you so surprised? Did you think I wouldn't know?"

"You—you bastard."

"Myunghoon hyung[1182]. No, Mr. Won Myunghoon."

Won Myunghoon froze. Not from humiliation, but from the crushing pressure bearing down on him.

A pressure unlike anything he had felt from Jin Taekyung before was pouring off him.

"Whatever you did or planned to do, I'll let everything up to this point slide. But…"

Beneath the tangled hair falling over his face, his darkened eyes gleamed.

"Never bare your teeth at me again."

"…!"

[1182] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean form of address used by a man for an older man.

“I’m done. Get lost.”

Won Myunghoon’s lips moved, but no words came out.

He stared at Jin Taekyung with an unreadable look, then spun around.

He could feel the Peace Guild members’ gazes boring into the back of his head. Only now had they realized something had been going on.

Fucking idiots. How dare they…

But it didn’t matter.

Jin Taekyung and those ragtag Guild members would all be dead soon anyway.

A short while later, as Won Myunghoon and the Star Guild members ran with all their might, a roar echoed from far away.

Chapter 220

Won Myunghoon left. Remembering how he had ground his teeth at my attitude yet hadn't dared attack drew a quiet laugh from me.

If he had, I would've made him regret it.

He was a hyena of a man.

Show him weakness, and he bared his teeth. Show him strength, and he hid them.

Judging by everything I had seen of him, his nature probably had something to do with the incident eight years ago as well.

Consider yourself lucky.

No matter how much a hyena leaped or crawled, it was still a beast.

If it knew when to tuck its tail, all I had to do was scare it off.

I had neither reason nor desire to bloody my hands before it actually sank its teeth into my shoulder—especially when I was about to face a real monster.

—Kyaaaaaaaah!

The black dot drew closer.

A rage-filled roar echoed from the far edge of the horizon.

Just as I had recognized it, it had recognized me.

Yes. You remember me too.

That was enough. I was about to face a half-mad Named Monster, but I felt neither fear nor excitement.

Only one thing bothered me, like a thorn caught in my throat.

"Why didn't you leave?"

Team Leader Choi stared at me with his arms loosely folded.

Instead of answering, he asked a question of his own.

"Who are you asking?"

"All of you."

I swept my gaze around. Four people stood against the endless wasteland, with rocks and trees scattered here and there behind them.

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim. Im Kkeokjeong and Song Song.

Not one of them had left.

"You all know that thing coming toward us is a Named Monster, right?"

"We're all well aware."

"Then this should be simple. It's dangerous, so leave while you still can."

"Where would we retreat to?"

"Where else? Back to the exit we came through."

"The Star Guild isn't exactly an ideal group to flee with—especially after making an enemy of their Guild Master."

I don't see it that way.

No one knew it yet, but Butler Kim was an A-Rank mage—and one who had lived through the unprecedented war known as the Great Cataclysm.

The Star Guild might have had the advantage in numbers, but even without me, the others wouldn't be outmatched if they fought Won Myunghoon's Guild right now.

"That's a convenient excuse."

Team Leader Choi stared at me as I smiled.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"No."

I cut him off before he could begin, but Team Leader Choi wasn't the sort to back down quietly.

"Since you've left me stuck here with nowhere to go, I think I've earned the right to ask a few questions."

Damn. He has a point.

I answered reluctantly.

"Fine…but keep it short."

"That monster coming toward us—is it connected to what happened three years ago?"

I hesitated, then nodded.

"You have no intention of retreating."

"…"

My silence was answer enough.

Team Leader Choi let out a low sigh.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, you're facing a Named Monster."

"That's news to me. All I see is something I need to kill."

"You need to think about this rationally."

"Do I look that unstable right now?"

"That…"

Team Leader Choi fell silent.

I was calmer than I had ever been. My heart might have been hammering like mad, but my mind was running through countless ways to deal with the creature.

"Team Leader Choi."

"…?"

"I've told you my motto in life a few times before, haven't I?"

Im Kkeokjeong, who had been watching in silence, answered for him.

"Thin and long."

"You remember too, Uncle?"

“You were a strange kid. Most young men dream big at least once…but you never did.”

“I’ve never been fond of a turbulent life.”

This time, Butler Kim answered with a smile.

“For someone who feels that way, you seem to have come quite far.”

“That’s why I changed it.”

“Big and long. Is that right?”

“Yes. It’s already too late for me to live small. Since things have turned out this way, I’m going to live as big and as long as I can.”

“Good. If you wish, perhaps…”

I knew what he was about to say.

I quietly shook my head. Butler Kim had a far more important task to handle.

“I’m fine. Protect the others.”

“Understood. Even without being asked, I’ll do what must be done to the best of my ability.”

At Butler Kim’s clear-cut answer, Song Song asked with an incredulous expression,

“You’re going to let him fight a Named Monster alone? Are you all out of your minds? One wrong move and we’ll all die. Every last one of us!”

“Then why haven’t you left, Miss Song?”

“…Good question. Why am I still here?”

I watched her sink into thought, then spoke.

“Miss Song.”

“No.”

“Absolutely not.”

“Hunter Jin Taekyung. Please.”

What was with these reactions?

I had barely gotten her name out, yet Song Song, Team Leader Choi, and Butler Kim had all shut me down without hesitation.

“Taekyung, go for it.”

At least Kkeokjeong hyung[1183] was on my side.

I looked at the other three with an aggrieved expression.

“I haven’t even said anything yet.”

Song Song answered,

“That’s why I’m saying no.”

“How do you know what I was going to say?”

“Hmm. A confession?”

[1183] *Hyung* is a term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close; it means “older brother.”

My head went numb for a moment.

The back of my skull throbbed as though someone had hit it with a hammer.

“Wait. How did you know?”

“Good grief. How could I not know?”

“W-was it that obvious?”

“Yes. Painfully.”

“Then…”

She shook her head without hesitation.

“I’m sorry. I’m not the sort of person who changes her attitude at the drop of a hat just because someone has money or fame.”

“Oh.”

“To be honest, you’re quite a catch, Mr. Taekyung. But when I like someone, I’m the type to reel him in all at once. I can’t keep a whole pond stocked with men.”

After letting everything out in one breath, she blinked.

“Oh. I wasn’t too harsh on someone who’s about to fight a Named Monster, was I?”

I had been opening and closing my mouth like a goldfish, but a quiet laugh soon escaped me.

“Why are you laughing?”

“No reason. I was just thinking how refreshingly straightforward you are.”

She narrowed her eyes at my answer.

“Hold on. Why are you suddenly speaking casually?”

“You said you’re twenty-seven, right? We’re the same age. We can at least be friends, can’t we?”

“Hmm. There’s no such thing as friendship between a man and a woman.”

“We can worry about that if the time comes.”

When Song Song still hesitated, I added,

“We’re guildmates, after all.”

“…When you put it that way, I can’t exactly refuse.”

I grinned at her.

In the end, I had been rejected cleanly, but I didn’t regret it in the slightest. If anything, I felt strangely calm.

If someone saw me like this and asked whether I had really liked Song Song, the answer was yes. There was no question about that.

But even I couldn’t say for certain what I felt now.

I had simply said what I had kept buried in my heart for so long, and regardless of her answer, I felt relieved.

Maybe that was enough for now.

"Let's have some soju[1184] when this is over."

"My family motto says boys and girls over seven shouldn't sit together."

"I meant all of us."

"…Oh. Right."

I turned away with a light step.

At that moment, I sensed an enormous flow of mana behind me. I didn't need to look to know that Butler Kim was layering magical barriers around the others.

I'm counting on you.

It meant the battle was close at hand. Sure enough, the creature that had been no more than a tiny dot was now close enough for even an ordinary person to see clearly.

"Bastard, you've gotten big."

Its body was easily over fifty meters[1185] long, and its wings were larger still.

Black scales covered every inch of it, gleaming in the light of the setting sun.

It had grown at least two or three times larger than when I had last seen it three years ago.

Was that even possible?

I had never heard of anything like it.

But there was no mistaking the creature. Its clouded eye was proof.

Its remaining eye, stained crimson, stared directly at me.

—Kraaaaaaaah!

Whoooosh!

A single roar sent a tremendous gust crashing over the wasteland. Dirt and pebbles flew into the air, filling it with a thick cloud of dust.

When the curtain of dust settled, a massive silhouette stood atop a nearby hill.

It's huge.

And strong.

With my senses stretched wide, I could feel its rage and power.

It was a monster that had broken free of the bounds of A-Rank.

It possessed the majesty befitting a Named Monster.

"So we finally meet."

Now that I stood face-to-face with it, my chest trembled. Three years ago, I had lost my comrades, and it had lost one eye.

It had been a long, bitter grudge.

Now it was time to end it.

I tightened my grip on the cold spear shaft and slowly walked toward the creature.

[1184] *Soju* is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

[1185] Fifty meters is about 164 ft.

“Long time no see. Remember me?”

Wyverns were unquestionably advanced creatures.

It had been cunning and cruel even then. Now that it had become a Named Monster, it naturally possessed even greater strength and Intelligence.

—Grrrrr…

“Looks like you do. So, how’s the eye?”

A crimson flame blazed in its remaining eye. I let out a quiet laugh as the scales across its body bristled.

“You fucking bastard. Who the hell do you think you’re hissing at?”

—Grrrk!

One step.

Then another.

My heart pounded while my mind spun at full speed. Hundreds of ways to carve apart its body and snuff out its life unfolded before my eyes.

“There were some names I wanted you to hear if I ever saw you again. Open your ears and listen carefully.”

Step.

Step.

As the distance between us narrowed, something hot surged from my lower abdomen.

It was like a small sun—the Scorching Yang Qi that had surpassed one jiazi[1186], and the rage that had built and built until it became something solid.

“Kim Hyunsu.”

The face of a straight-laced kid in horn-rimmed glasses appeared before my eyes.

He had been a Hunter for only four months. He was the first to die. One sweep of the creature’s tail had crushed his entire body.

He had been clumsy, but he never lacked enthusiasm. Whenever he had a spare moment, he would come find me with another question.

Deputy Team Leader. How do I do this?

Deputy Team Leader. I don’t understand this part.

Deputy Team Leader…

Sometimes, I thought about him.

I wondered whether he might have survived if I had explained things more thoroughly, if I hadn’t been annoyed by the kid who came to me with dozens of questions every day.

But regret always came too late. Kim Hyunsu had remained twenty forever, and his parents had wailed throughout the funeral for the only son they had lost.

[1186] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here to measure accumulated internal energy.

Maybe they still are, even three years later.

There were nine more people like him.

Every one of them had a family and dreams of their own.

“Lee Hyerim. Song Donghyeok, Park Sangho, Kim Haneung, Park Gwanghyeon…”

With every name, I took another step. With every step, memories of that person shimmered before me like heat haze.

That was why my vision blurred.

At least, that was what I chose to believe.

After ten steps, only one name remained.

“…And Hong Cheonsu.”

The round face of a man in his thirties flashed before my eyes.

When I first met him, I was a rookie Hunter barely twenty years old, while he was a ten-year veteran.

After he saved me from being surrounded and nearly killed by goblins, I started calling him hyung[1187].

One perfectly ordinary day, I had suddenly asked him,

Why are you always so good to me?

He had answered,

It kept eating at me, seeing a kid like you struggle. My youngest sibling is about your age.

It wasn’t until the day of his funeral that I learned he had grown up in an orphanage and didn’t have a single relative.

The absurdity of it made me laugh.

In the end, though, I cried.

Because I remembered his final words.

You cocky bastard. Taekyung, go on ahead.

That was how he—Cheonsu hyung[1188]—died.

Leaving behind a wonderful spouse and three children.

And now, at this very moment, I stood before the creature. I glared into its enormous red eye and opened my mouth.

“Listen carefully, you fucking lizard bastard.”

I had survived countless crises to say these words.

After three years and ninety-two days, I was finally ready to tear off those wings and drive my spear into its heart.

“This time, I’m not going anywhere.”

[1187] *Hyung* is a term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close; it means “older brother.”

[1188] *Hyung* is a term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close; it means “older brother.”

Internal energy erupted from my dantian and surged through every limb and bone in my body.

The Scorching Yang Qi raced unchecked toward the cold spearhead. The internal energy flowed in an unbroken stream, tangling like a skein of thread before transforming into something new.

Crackle, crackle, crackle!

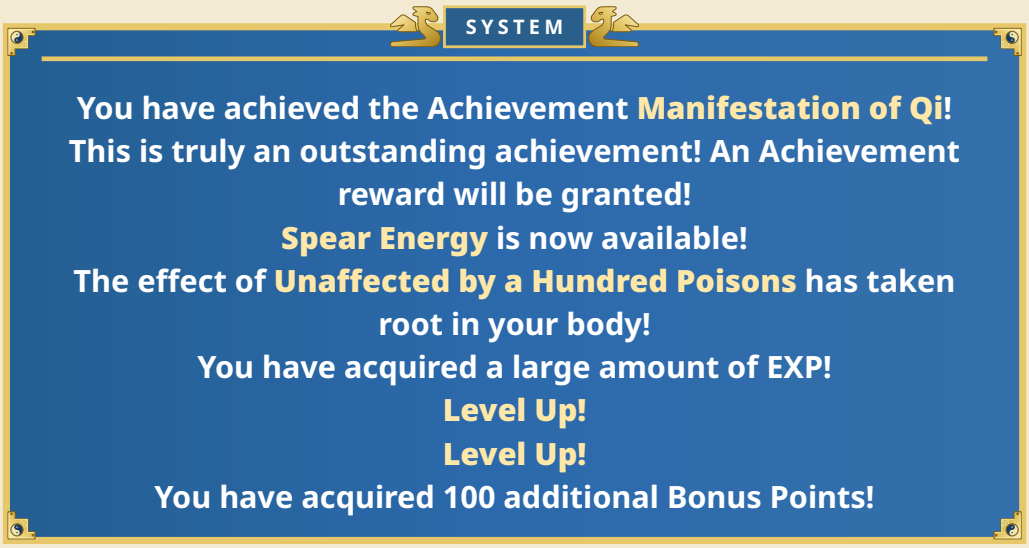
Aura. Spear Energy.

It didn’t matter what I called it. I leveled the blue-burning spearhead at the creature.

“You’re…dead today.”

Chapter 221

Ding.



The System notifications echoed in my ears like a ringing bell. But my gaze remained fixed solely on the spear.

Ssssss.

Blue flames flickered over the spearhead. A thrilling shiver raced up my spine.

I did it.

Today, I had taken one step toward a higher realm and conquered one of the peaks of the perilous mountain known as martial arts.

At the same time, I knew one thing for certain.

I can kill it.

No more thoughts or words were needed. All that remained was to act and make those long years of waiting a reality.

But I wasn't the only one who had been waiting for this touching reunion.

Its lone eye bulging wide, the creature let out a furious roar.

—Kraaaaaaaah!

No, it was closer to a thunderclap than a roar.

Goooooooom—

Tremendous wind pressure poured from a maw large enough to swallow a car whole and bore down on the ground. The compressed air burst around me, and it felt as though a thousand-geun boulder were crushing my shoulders.[1189]

Air Breath.

One branch of a unique ability granted only to dragonkin.

[1189] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is 600 kg (about 1,300 lb).

Since a Named Monster was using it, even a capable Hunter would have had their eardrums burst and been forced to their knees.

But not me.

Crack. Grrrk.

I silently pressed forward against the crushing pressure.

With every step, my ankles sank into the ground and the pressure grew stronger, but it couldn't stop me.

The creature might have surpassed the limits of an ordinary monster, but I wasn't afraid.

Because so have I.

At least in terms of physical ability, I could already be called superhuman.

Strength, speed, stamina—when it came to everything that determined the outcome of a battle, I stood one step ahead of a Peak master at my level, or an A-Rank Hunter.

"Ahh, that's refreshing."

I raised my head with a grin.

Atop its skyscraper-sized torso, the red eye of the creature blasting out Air Breath wavered when it saw my smile.

"What was that? A fan set to high?"

—Kraaaaaaaah!

"Turn it off! You're blowing yellow dust everywhere, you bastard!"[1190]

As I shouted, I swung the spear toward the sky with all my strength.

Whooooooosh!

The blue flame of qi carved a semicircle through the air, burning through it. In that instant, the pressure crushing my body vanished, and I became as light as a feather.

Now!

Boom!

With a single stomp, I shot forward like an arrow.

The confused creature twisted its head and unleashed another Air Breath, but it couldn't keep up with my speed.

Whoosh! Rat-a-tat-tat!

Clad in nothing but light leather armor and carrying a single spear, I streaked across the battlefield like lightning. In the blink of an eye, I was right in front of it.

—Grrrrrk?

The startled creature spread its folded wings wide. But by then, I had already leaped with all my strength.

[1190] Yellow dust is windborne dust from the deserts of East Asia that can reach Korea.

Boom!

With a powerful tremor, I soared into the air. Through my hair streaming in the wind, I saw the creature's knee beneath its flashing black scales.

The exact spot known as the cruciate ligament.

"You're exempt from military service, you bastard!"[1191]

With that shout, I drove my spear in with all my strength.

Thrust! Shrrrk!

The Wyvern's hide and scales, said to withstand ordinary magic and weapons alike, split open in an instant.

A sharp, satisfying jolt traveled through my fingertips, like harpooning a fish.

It went in!

The blue-burning Spear Energy cut through and shattered everything in its path.

Once the spearhead opened a gap, the rest was easy. Like hammering in a nail, I slammed my fist against the butt of the two-meter spear and drove it deep into the creature's knee.[1192]

Boom! Fwoooosh!

Dark blood erupted like a fountain. Just as the creature spread its wings to take flight, it dropped to one knee with a scream.

—Graaaaaaaah!

But I didn't stop there. I stepped onto the end of the spear lodged in its knee and used its spring to launch myself upward.

As I shot several more meters into the air, a dagger appeared in my hand.[1193]

If I don't have one, I can just take one out.

I had countless weapons stored in my Inventory, both in Murim and in the real world.

They had cost me a fortune, but if it meant killing this creature, I wouldn't mind spending ten times as much.

Thrust!

I suddenly remembered training in the Wall Lizard Technique back in Murim. The cliff I had scaled then was even higher, and there had hardly been anything to use as a foothold.

And whenever I thought I'd made some progress, a certain lunatic would start dropping rocks on me.

Compared to that, this was nothing.

I drove my dagger into the creature's enormous body again and again, climbing higher and higher.

[1191] South Korea requires military service from most men; a serious knee injury can qualify someone for an exemption.

[1192] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.

[1193] One meter is about 3.3 ft, so several meters is several yards.

Thrust, thrust! Thrust-thrust-thrust!

Against Spear Energy, neither hide harder than plate armor nor scales capable of deflecting low-level magic were of any use.

Imagine something the size of your palm crawling up your body and hammering nails into you over and over.

That was exactly what the creature was going through.

—Kraaaaaaah!

Unable to endure the relentless pain, it writhed and roared. It was trying to shake me off, but it was one step too late.

By then, I was already savoring the sensation of floating through the air.

Open Inventory. Equip spear.

The next instant, a solid spear shaft filled my empty hand.

The Scorching Yang Qi that had surpassed one jiazi when I opened my Conception and Governor Vessels surged toward the spearhead like an ebbing tide.[1194]

Whooooooosh. Ssssss!

Blue flames enveloped the spearhead without leaving the slightest gap.

Flickering in the darkness, they were the tail of a meteor.

And I was the meteor itself.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

With that quiet murmur, I became one with the spear and plunged downward. My target was its wing, which served as both foreleg and arm.

Blinded by pain for a moment, the creature had no way to stop the meteor.

Fwoosh! Shraaaaaak!

Scorching Yang Qi blazed like a miniature sun, slicing through hide and scales and burning the flesh beneath. The wing, more than ten meters from top to bottom, split in two along the path of the spearhead.[1195]

—Krrrk…!

It was probably the worst pain the creature had ever experienced. The red eye of a beast that had spent its entire life as a predator flew wide.

—Kraaaaaaaaaah!

I landed lightly on the ground and regarded it with a cold, steady gaze.

Its fifty-meter bulk writhed within the billowing cloud of dust.[1196]

“Does it hurt?”

—Kwak! Kraaaaaah!

“That little?”

Compared to what it had done three years ago, this was nothing.

[1194] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; here it describes an amount of cultivated internal energy.

[1195] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

[1196] Fifty meters is about 164 ft.

A single flap of its wings had shattered entire bodies. Heads clutched in its claws had vanished without a trace. Those swallowed by its enormous maw hadn't even left corpses behind.

That was when I first learned how much blood and how many organs the human body contained.

How brutally a person could die.

"You bastard. I wouldn't be satisfied even if I chewed you to death."

An eye for an eye. A tooth for a tooth.

It would die here today, by my hand. And it would die horribly—exactly as I had imagined countless times before.

"This is just the beginning. Quit whining and get up."

Whoooosh.

The wind stirred by my swinging spear swept away the dust.

Covered in blood and dirt, the creature glared at me as it panted heavily.

—Krrrk.

Dozens of blades were embedded throughout its body, and blood poured from its open wounds like waterfalls.

Of the wings that symbolized the Wyvern, only one remained.

It was still enormous and imposing, but there was no longer any trace of the dignity befitting a dragonkin offshoot and a Named Monster.

—Grrrrr…

Its eye, brimming with resentment and killing intent, glared at me.

The emotions conveyed by that gaze were unlike anything I had ever known from a monster.

"Watch how you look at me, or I'll pluck that eye out first."

I tossed out the words and began walking toward it.

That was when it happened.

—Hu. man.

"…!"

A single word made me doubt my own ears.

My feet froze. The corner of my eye twitched involuntarily.

What did I just hear?

But I hadn't misheard it. The creature's maw shifted, and a clearer pronunciation emerged.

—Do. you. want. to. kill. me?

A monster was speaking.

That very *monster*.

A groan slipped through my parted lips.

“This is impossible…”

—It’s. dif.fer.ent. from. be.fore.

The instant it finished speaking, its red eye turned completely bloodred.

And then…

—Heal.

Sssssss.

Magical power began gathering around the creature.

Carus the One-Eyed.

That was the Black Wyvern’s name.

Before earning that name, he had survived countless crises. He had fought not only monsters, but humans as well.

He had fought hundreds of battles where victory meant claiming prey and defeat meant becoming prey.

That day in the past had been no different.

Not until one human took his eye.

How dare he? How dare a human lower than a bug do this to me!

Carus was furious. At the same time, he made a vow.

He would kill the human who had taken his eye. Even if he never found him, he would kill other humans again and again.

Then one day, after endless battle and slaughter, he realized that he had grown to an enormous size and gained tremendous strength.

Why? Did fighting humans make me stronger?

Before long, Carus understood. It wasn’t his battles with humans that had made him stronger, but devouring other monsters.

Each time he did, something inside his body grew more powerful.

What did the humans call it again? Ah, right.

Magic Gems.

Once he understood the source of his strength, Carus began hunting Magic Gems.

He devoured other monsters, and instead of feasting on human flesh, he studied the magic equipment they carried.

So this is how those human bastards use Magic Gems.

The more Magic Gems he absorbed, the higher his Intelligence rose and the stronger he became.

As a Wyvern, a lesser branch of the dragonkin, Carus had possessed remarkable Intelligence to begin with. At last, he set foot in an entirely new realm.

Magic, huh? Should I learn it?

Carus built a new nest in a nameless wasteland. He killed everything that might get in his way and immersed himself in the study of magic.

Then he noticed the humans invading his territory.

I haven't even finished digesting the Magic Gems I ate earlier...

Knowing that he was still incomplete, Carus decided to be patient.

Even when several humans recklessly approached his nest, he tried to ignore them.

Until he caught *that bastard's* scent.

My eye! It's the human who took my eye!

Carus saw red and immediately raced across the wasteland.

Using one of the humans he had deliberately allowed to escape as a guide, he finally came face-to-face with that bastard.

I'll kill him! I'll chew him up, bones and all!

But that bastard was strong. Even Carus, who had absorbed hundreds of Magic Gems, was pushed back helplessly.

Yet he still had one card left to play.

—Heal.

Sssssss.

His wounds closed, and the bleeding stopped. He couldn't completely restore his torn wing, but this was enough.

—I'll. kill. you. hu.man.

Jin Taekyung, his face filled with shock, clenched his teeth.

Having already experienced Jin Taekyung's speed firsthand, Carus cast another spell without hesitation.

—Sloooow!

A faint trace of dragon blood flowed through Carus's veins.

Five Slow spells stacked atop one another and enveloped Jin Taekyung's body.

—Kehahahaha!

Carus burst into laughter as he watched Jin Taekyung move as slowly as possible.

That was when Jin Taekyung spoke.

"One hundred points to Agility."

—...?

Whoosh.

Carus blinked.

A spearhead wreathed in blue flames filled his enormous eye.

"What are you looking at, you fucking bastard?"

Crunch!

Chapter 222

Ssssss.

Blue flames flickered over the spearhead.

They were a concentration of immense qi—powerful enough to pierce even the Wyvern's steel-like hide and scales.

There was no way they would fail to penetrate its eye, the Wyvern's only real weakness.

"What are you looking at, you fucking bastard?"

Without the slightest hesitation, I drove my spear into its enormous eye.

Crunch! Ssssss!

Hide? Scales?

Nothing could stop the spearhead.

Blood gushed out as the Scorching Yang Qi burned through its retina. Its vertically slit pupil dilated, and its maw stretched so wide it looked ready to tear apart.

"Graaaaaaaah!"

It was a howl from the depths of its soul.

An inhuman shriek I had never heard before burst from its mouth, which was stretched wide enough to split.

That nearly blew out my eardrums.

Even after raising my internal energy to protect my hearing, my ears were still ringing.

Leaving the spear embedded in its eye, I landed lightly on the ground and watched the creature writhe.

Boom! Kwoooooom!

It thrashed wildly, swinging its one intact wing and tail in every direction. Then it suddenly jerked its head up.

"Grrrrr."

The head of the house-sized monster.

Black blood poured from the eye, which had been half crushed.

It was a horrifying sight—enough to make even a fairly gutsy person step backward. But as I watched, I felt refreshed, as if someone had opened a hole in my chest.

"You're one dumb son of a bitch. You still haven't learned your lesson after what happened three years ago?"

Even if it had lost both eyes, it still had other senses.

Its head trembled with pain as it turned directly toward me.

"Hu. man."

"Why, Wyvern?"

"How. did. you. even?"

I grinned at the disbelief in its voice.

It was almost a shame the bastard couldn't see my smile.

"If you wish hard enough, the whole universe will help you. Something like that."[1197]

"My. ma. gic. was. per. fect!"

"Oh, I'll give you that. You caught me by surprise."

What kind of monster was a Wyvern?

It had a body and wings as large as a building, a hide tough enough to deflect most attacks, and even the ability to use Breath.

It was terrifying enough on pure physical ability alone. I had never dreamed it might know magic too.

Or that one measly Slow spell would cut my Agility by fifty.

According to the System notification, its magic had been amplified several times over by the **dragonkin** trait.

But I still had one trump card left.

"I've saved up quite a few points. Saving is a habit of mine."

Back when I was a rookie in Murim, I had raised my stats with every point I earned.

I had been weak then, and my situation was so precarious that there was no telling what might happen the next day.

But as I grew stronger, I realized something.

These points could be a weapon too.

Just as martial artists concealed their ultimate techniques until the very end.

"What. kind. of. orc. shit. is. that?"

"What do you think? It means your magic won't do a damn thing to me."

I leisurely opened my Inventory and pulled out a new spear. When I tapped the spearhead with my fingernail, a clear ring echoed through the air.

The blind creature jerked at the sound.

"What. are. you. plan. ning?"

"You already know. Why ask?"

Step. Step.

With every step I took toward it, its tightly hunched body flinched.

"We have an outstanding debt to settle. With three years of interest."

[1197] A reference to a saying associated with former South Korean president Park Geun-hye about the universe helping those who wish for something earnestly.

There was no room for compromise. This fight would end only when one of us died.

And I wasn't the one dying here today.

"I'm going to kill you."

"Kraaaaaah!"

But the creature wasn't about to take it lying down.

It had lost one wing and both eyes to me, but it was still a Named Monster. It had enough strength left for one final struggle.

"Heal!"

Sssssss.

Black mana once again enveloped its enormous body. The bleeding stopped at once, and new flesh began to fill the wounds. It was far faster than any healing magic I had ever seen.

And it wasn't finished.

"Dark. Bin. ding!"

Shrrrrrrk!

Thorny vines erupted without warning from the dusty wasteland and wrapped tightly around my entire body.

At the same time, a System notification sounded.

Beep!

SYSTEM

Lv.??? Carus has used Binding Magic!
Due to the dragonkin trait, the magic is enhanced!
Strength temporarily decreased by 10!
Stamina temporarily decreased by 10!
Agility temporarily decreased by 10!

The thorny vines crept upward from my ankles, coiling around my legs, waist, arms, and finally my neck.

Sawtoothed thorns pierced my thin leather armor and dug into my skin.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Paralysis Poison has entered your body!
Nerve Poison has entered your body!
Status abnormality: Poisoned!

"...Huh. What the hell is this?"

“Grrrrr.”

The creature—or rather, Carus—laughed triumphantly. Its mangled eye was already beginning to return to its original form.

“You. let. your. guard. down. hu. man!”

“Let my guard down?”

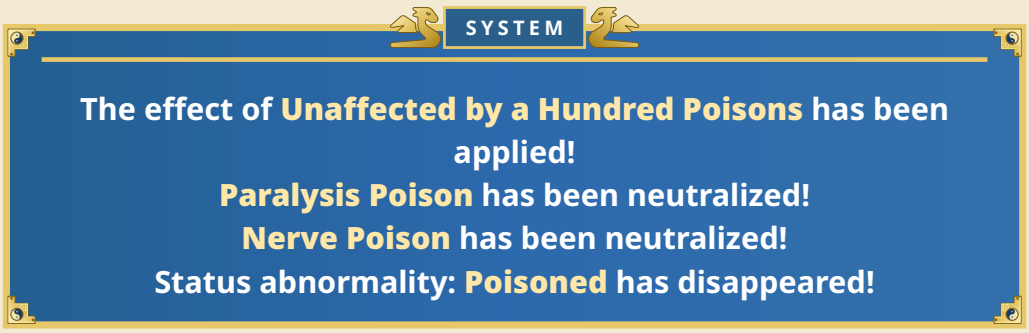
I thought for a moment, then nodded.

“Yeah. I did let my guard down.”

“…Why. are. you. so. calm?”

“When someone acts calm in a situation like this, it usually means one of two things. Either they’re bluffing their ass off, or…”

Ding.



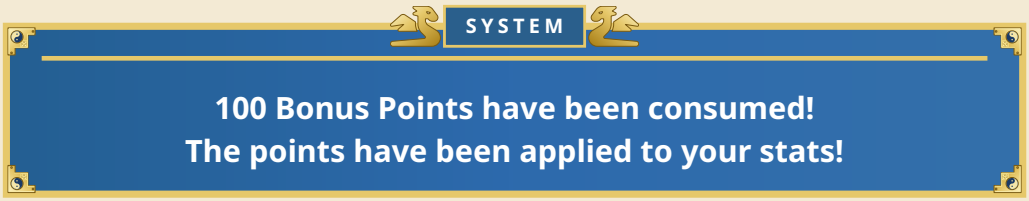
“Or they have a good reason not to worry.”

The instant I finished speaking, I stepped forward.

The thorny vines, each as thick as my thigh, tightened around my entire body, but they couldn’t stop me.

“While I’m at it, I’ll splurge on a bonus. Fifty Strength. Fifty Stamina.”

Ding.



Crack. Crrrunch.

I tore and shattered the vines with overwhelming power and Strength.

Carus’s magic had been greatly amplified by the dragonkin trait, but the magic itself wasn’t particularly advanced.

“Slow magic, binding magic. What’s next?”

Its eye had already almost completely healed.

When Carus saw me emerge from the vines unharmed, its maw fell open.

“You…you!”

I brushed the pieces of vine from my arm.

"Don't you have any other spells? You were so confident, I thought you'd at least know how to factor, but it turns out you've only mastered addition and subtraction."

"How. did. you?"

"My own magic."

"Your. own. ma. gic?"

"Yeah. Magic."

I shifted the iron spear in my hand into a reverse grip.

That was all the preparation I needed. This spear was my magic, and the creature would never be able to stop it.

"Huuup."

I drew a deep breath. Every muscle in my body meshed together like tiny gears, and the world slowed.

I leaned back and snapped my arm forward, casting a spell I hadn't quite memorized.

"Burst, sesame."[1198]

Whoosh! Fwooooooosh!

Against the red sunset staining the horizon, a blue flash plunged into the creature's eye, which was dyed an even deeper shade of blood.

Burning. Shattering. Bursting.

Crack!

"Graa…aaaaaaah!"

I walked toward it as its agonized scream tore through the air. With every step, familiar faces flashed before my eyes.

Faces I would probably remember until the day I died.

Ever since that day three years ago, shackles had weighed down my ankles.

Anger. Guilt. The desire for revenge. Emotions piled one atop another, layer upon layer.

Their weight had been crushing. So heavy I couldn't take a single step forward.

But now…

At some point, I had grown strong enough to bear that weight.

At long last, I could offer some comfort to the spirits of those who had died before me.

Yes. Finally.

Just as I murmured those words silently in my heart, mana rippled around the creature writhing in pain.

[1198] A variation on "Open Sesame," the command that opens the cave in *Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves*.

“Kraaaah! Slow! Dark Binding! Magic Arrow!”

Three spells erupted in rapid succession.

I kicked off the ground and charged forward. The instant I shot beyond Slow’s area of effect like a streak of light, thorny vines and dozens of mana arrows rose to block my path.

Sssshing! Shrrrk!

Everything was sliced apart along the arc of blue flame. Sensing that its attack had failed, the creature beat its one remaining wing.

It was such an enormous target that I didn’t even need to aim. Another flash shot from my hand.

Swooooooosh! Thud!

“Kyaaaaaaah!”

Whoooosh!

A shrill scream rang out. Then its spike-covered tail came hurtling toward me with a terrifying roar as it tore through the air.

Boom!

But I had already leaped half a beat ahead of it.

The rocks scattered across the wasteland like reefs rising from the sea shattered into powder.

Open Inventory. Equip.

As I descended, I swung my spear.

Shraaaak.

The severed tail rolled through the dust with black blood spilling from it.

“Kraaaaah!”

Shrrk. Shrrk. Shrrk.

It was like perfectly meshing gears.

I blocked, dodged, and cut through every attack the creature unleashed in its desperate struggle.

Then I realized that no more attacks were coming and stopped.

“Krrk. Grrrk.”

Two severed wings. A severed tail. Two eyes that could no longer function.

The creature lay submerged in a vast pool of blood, ragged breaths rasping from its maw as though each one might be its last.

I watched it for a while before opening my mouth.

“Do you want to live?”

“…”

“Then use your healing magic. I’ll wait.”

“Will. you…save. me?”

“No. It just feels like a waste to send you off like this.”

“…!”

“Hold out ten more times. I’ll kill you after that.”

The creature’s body trembled. Its gaping eye, pouring dark-red blood like a waterfall, turned toward me.

“You. are. cruel. hu. man.”

“Compared to what you did, this is nothing.”

“I. only. did. what. I. had. to. do.”

“I know.”

Humans killed monsters, and monsters killed humans.

The two sides had been killing each other for decades. It was both history and an inescapable cycle. And…

“I’m no different.”

Completing my revenge—that was what I had to do now.

After a brief silence, a resigned whisper escaped its maw.

“…Kill. me.”

The strength slowly drained from its twitching body.

I aimed my spear between its blood-caked eyes and whispered softly.

“Thank you.”

For staying alive until now.

And for dying by my hand.

With those barely audible words, I drove the spear forward.

Shnk.

The Scorching Yang Qi flowing from the spearhead as it gently pierced through the center of its brow rampaged like a wild beast, devouring and burning everything in its path.

A skull harder than steel. Flesh. Brain matter. Everything else.

Ding.

System notifications washed over me like waves. I released the scorching-hot spear shaft and thought,

I did it. Finally.

What more was there to say?

The shouts of other people brought me back to myself as I stood there in a daze.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung!”

“Taekyung!”

Team Leader Choi. Butler Kim. Im Kkeokjeong. Song Song.

The guildmates I had met through new bonds.

My people.

As I watched them race toward me, I let out a weary laugh.

Chapter 223

A thrill.

That was what everyone who had witnessed the battle felt.

They had known for some time that Jin Taekyung was extraordinarily skilled. They had also known that what they had seen so far wasn't the full extent of his abilities.

But who knew he was this strong?

Team Leader Choi—or rather, Choi Minwoo—swallowed dryly.

Though it had only been a few months, no one had observed Jin Taekyung more closely than he had.

Yet at that moment, Choi Minwoo realized that every judgment he had made about Jin Taekyung had been wrong.

What… exactly is this man?

Everything he had seen until now had been no more than the tip of the iceberg.

A few months ago, when they had first met at a Hunter staffing agency, Taekyung had volunteered to work as a porter for a few hundred thousand won[1199] a day.

Now, he had hunted a Named Monster alone.

And utterly overwhelmed it.

Puhk!

The spearhead infused with Aura pierced the monster between the eyes.

It was the moment an immensely powerful Named Monster died at the hands of a single person.

It was also the moment a new legend was born.

"Young Master."

"…Ah."

Choi Minwoo had been dazed for a moment, but Butler Kim's call finally brought him back to his senses.

When he looked around, everyone had a similar expression.

Shock. And more shock.

Trembling with an indescribable thrill, they rushed toward Jin Taekyung as if by prior agreement.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung!"

"Taekyung!"

Jin Taekyung smiled at them. It was a relieved smile, as if he had finally cast off even the slightest trace of regret.

[1199] A few hundred thousand Korean won—roughly 200,000–500,000 won—is about $140–$360 or €130–€320.

Choi Minwoo let out a hollow laugh.

“You can smile at a time like this?”

“I don’t know. I can’t think of anything else to do.”

“Then shout, at least. We’re the only ones here anyway.”

“Something like, ‘I killed a Named Monster!‘?”

“Yes. Now it’s finally starting to feel real.”

Choi Minwoo stared at Jin Taekyung as he scratched the back of his head, then abruptly held out his hand.

A sentence he had momentarily forgotten had come back to him.

Something he had wanted to say if—just if—Taekyung won.

“Thank you for all your hard work.”

“…”

“You’ve truly been through so much.”

For an instant, Jin Taekyung’s eyelids trembled.

An indescribable emotion flickered through his clear, deep-black eyes. Then he firmly clasped Choi Minwoo’s hand.

“Thank you. All of you.”

For a while, I couldn’t come to my senses amid the barrage of questions and congratulations flying at me from every direction.

“So that was already thirty years ago. The Great Cataclysm was still in full swing at the time…”

“Ah, yes.”

Butler Kim, who rarely showed much emotion, excitedly rattled off one incident after another from the Great Cataclysm.

“My goodness. This isn’t a dream, is it? No, it isn’t, right?”

“Uh, no.”

Song Song stared at me as if she still couldn’t tell whether she was dreaming or awake.

“Sniff. Taekyung! You bastard! Sniff, sob!”

“…Why are you crying again, Uncle?”

“Because I’m proud of you, you punk. I’m proud. Sniff!”

Im Kkeokjeong burst into tears as if his own child had made it back alive.

With all that going on, I didn’t have a chance to check the backlog of System messages.

In the end, Team Leader Choi was the one who brought order to the chaos.

“All right, everyone, calm down. Let’s deal with the cleanup first.”

“That’s a good idea, but…”

I cautiously asked the most important question.

“How are we supposed to clean this up?”

“…Oh. Well, you see…”

Even Team Leader Choi, who was never at a loss in any situation, looked flustered.

Cleaning up after a raid was routine, and the work was generally the same every time.

Check and treat the casualties, then sort through and collect the byproducts. If there was anything else, it was usually just inspecting the Equipment.

But this time was different.

This bastard’s torso alone is over fifty meters[1200] long.

And that was only counting its length. Its enormous girth, wings, tail, and everything else were separate problems.

Just thinking about how to deal with it was giving me a headache.

But we can’t just leave it here.

Processing the byproducts meant separating the hide, bones, and flesh.

The Carus I had brought down was a Named Monster, so its rarity and the difficulty of processing it were beyond imagination.

Fuck, what are we supposed to do with the scales?

They weren’t fish scales we could scrape off with a kitchen knife.

Aside from me, someone would have to be at least as capable as Butler Kim or Team Leader Choi to handle the job. Of course, there was one possible solution.

There was one method left.

It was both extremely easy and extremely difficult.

Inventory.

Based on everything I had experienced so far, the Inventory’s capacity was practically infinite. Besides, this was a monster’s corpse, not a living creature.

It was worth a try.

The problem comes afterward.

I could already picture everyone’s reaction if I put Carus’s corpse into my Inventory.

Even if I came clean to the guild members, suspicions would arise unless I intended to keep the byproducts forever.

Reporters are camped out at the Gate entrance, so how did he secretly carry all of it outside? Things like that.

If that happened, it might not be long before the entire country learned my secret.

[1200] Fifty meters is about 164 ft.

The front pages of the daily newspapers and every news headline would be decorated with my name.

> **Breaking News:** A-Rank Hunter Jin Taekyung Revealed to Be a System User

> **Interview with Jin Taekyung:** “Martial Arts Were the Easiest Part”

> **Hunter Association:** “Jin Taekyung’s Hunter License Must Be Revoked”

> **Jin Taekyung Blasts Hunter Association:** “Fuck, if You Don’t Like It, Use the System Yourselves”

> **NASA Official Statement:** “We Will Capture Him at All Costs and Subject Him to Experiments”

“…”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung? Is something wrong?”

“No. Just thinking about it made me dizzy.”

“Pardon?”

“It’s nothing.”

That could never be allowed to happen. Absolutely not.

In the end, after everyone put their heads together, we settled on one solution.

Team Leader Choi announced the verdict with the solemnity of a judge.

“Let’s bring in outside personnel.”

Gates weren’t immutable spaces, unchanging as evergreen trees.

After a certain amount of time, their destroyed environments and monsters were restored. This phenomenon was called Regen, and the time it took for a Gate to undergo Regen varied according to its Grade.

“As far as I know, A-Rank Gates usually undergo Regen once a week. Today is only the first day, so we have plenty of time.”

We would bring in outside personnel as quickly as possible to speed up the work. For now, it was the most reasonable and feasible option.

There was, however, one small problem with the plan.

“The exit Gate hasn’t opened.”

That was exactly what had happened.

Now that we had beaten the Named Monster to death, the exit should have opened. Yet even after several dozen minutes, it still showed no sign of appearing.

Im Kkeokjeong also looked around anxiously.

“Yeah, why hasn’t it opened? Is the Gate broken?”

“…”

What a horrifying thing to say.

As if Login Murim wasn’t enough, now there was Login Gate? If that was what this was, I’d rather bite my tongue and die.

Just as an ominous feeling began creeping over me, Butler Kim spoke.

“It appears the boss monster is still alive.”

“Alive? The boss monster?”

I pointed at Carus’s corpse, which lay facedown in a pool of blood, but Butler Kim shook his head.

“Named Monsters and boss monsters are different. To put it simply…the former is an uninvited guest, while the latter is the original homeowner.”

“The homeowner?”

“Yes. This may be easier to understand. If an armed intruder broke into your home, Hunter Jin Taekyung, what would you do?”

“I’d beat him until he begged me to kill him.”

“…I forgot. I meant if you were an ordinary person.”

“Oh. Then I’d run. If I thought I’d die before I could escape, I’d fight back.”

“The boss monster was no different. A powerful foe it could never hope to defeat appeared, so it fled in fear.”

The inside of a Gate was ultimately a world ruled by the law of the jungle.

The strong reigned, and the weak were trampled.

It might have been different for monsters that lived in tribes, but Wyverns were known to be solitary and ferocious. Carus wouldn’t have stopped after giving the boss monster a few knocks on the head and evicting it.

From the boss monster’s perspective, running away had been a fairly wise decision.

Unfortunately, that just made things more troublesome for us.

There was no way the thing had fled for its life only to hang around nearby grooming its claws.

It would have hidden as far away and as secretly as possible. And with only five people, searching this vast wasteland was impossible.

“Then…”

“We’ll have to go back to the entrance we came through.”

It was the obvious conclusion, and the right person for the job had already been decided.

Without giving it much thought, I shot my hand into the air.

“I’ll go.”

Team Leader Choi asked with concern in his eyes.

“You, Mr. Jin?”

“That seems like the fastest option. Doesn’t it?”

“That’s true, but you must be exhausted after the battle.”

I just leveled up, damn it. Let me go.

I swallowed the words that had risen to my throat and answered instead.

“I’m still full of energy. If you’re worried, I can have someone cast healing magic on me before I leave.”

“As you know, it’s a considerable distance to the entrance.”

“As you know, I’m pretty fast.”

It had taken us quite a while to reach this place the first time, but it would be different if I went alone. I wouldn’t have to stay on guard against monsters or match the pace of a group.

If I ran at full speed, I could reach the Gate entrance within an hour or two.

“Hmm. In that case, I’ll leave it to you. You and Butler Kim can go together.”

“Butler Kim, too?”

Butler Kim stroked his impressively full beard as he answered.

“We need to bring in outside personnel.”

Processing the byproducts of a Named Monster required Hunters who were at least B-Rank, if not A-Rank.

“I know a few people. If I go personally, they’ll probably drop everything and come running.”

“…”

That sounded about right.

I still couldn’t forget the sight of the Sangdong Guild Master doing PT exercises[1201] while loudly repeating orders.

It was something I could hardly believe even after seeing it.

Knowing Butler Kim’s spectacular track record, I could only nod. We needed him if we wanted to bring in outside personnel.

“So it’ll just be Butler Kim and me?”

“Yes.”

Butler Kim nodded and stepped behind me.

“All right. I’m ready.”

“Pardon?”

“Would you bend over a little?”

“…Why do you need me to bend over?”

No, what exactly was he ready for? Why did I need to bend over?

[1201] In South Korea, PT exercises are group calisthenics commonly associated with military training.

A terrible suspicion crossed my mind.

“You don’t mean…soap?”

“Please carry me on your back.”

“Oh. Sure.”

Thank goodness. He wasn’t a centaur.

I let out a sigh of relief and willingly offered my back to Butler Kim.

Thud-thud-thud-thud-thud!

With Butler Kim on my back, I raced forward without slowing down.

We ran into a pack of Orcs wandering through the wasteland, but that was the only interruption.

“Fire Rain.”

The magic of an A-Rank mage.

One-third of the Orcs died beneath the downpour of fire, and the rest scattered in every direction.

I felt like a mobile turret.

This isn’t bad.

Just as I was thinking about how much more efficient raids would be if I did them this way, we crossed the barren wasteland and spotted a dense jungle ahead.

“You’re astonishingly fast. We’ve already reached the jungle.”

“I’m going to slow down from here. With all this vegetation, we could get lost.”

“I’ll follow your lead, Hunter Jin Taekyung.”

The jungle was nothing but trees and undergrowth, making it a maze where one could easily lose their way.

We slowed down and continued along our bearings.

That was when it happened.

“…Huh.”

I suddenly stopped, letting out a hollow laugh.

Puzzled by my abrupt halt, Butler Kim asked,

“What is it?”

“It’s nothing. Just…”

How was I supposed to explain this?

At last, I found the right word and added softly,

“There are hyenas.”

“Hyenas?”

“Yes.”

Stupid, persistent hyenas that kept baring their teeth even after I had let them go once.

I crooked my finger toward the dense undergrowth in the distance.

“Come out, you fucking bastards.”

Rustle.

The undergrowth shook, and the hyenas emerged one by one.

But my eyes were fixed on only one person.

“Would you look at this insolent bastard.”

The leader of the hyenas bared his teeth and growled.

Chapter 224

A few hours earlier, Won Myunghoon's shout brought the dozen or so Star Guild members racing back toward the Gate entrance to a halt.

"Wait. Everyone, stop!"

Every eye turned toward him.

The terrifying Named Monster could appear behind them at any moment, yet Won Myunghoon had been lost in thought. At last, he opened his mouth.

"Scout."

"Yes, Guild Master."

The Guild member assigned to scouting answered immediately.

He was fast on his feet and skilled with a bow. Thanks to the good luck of drawing lots, he had barely escaped death, unlike his other comrades.

"Report our current location."

"According to the coordinates, we're at 175, 37, 990."

"Fuck the coordinates. How far are we from the Gate entrance?"

"At our current pace, approximately seven minutes."

"Not far, then. This is the only route to the Gate entrance, right?"

"…Yes. It is, but…"

The scout trailed off with an uneasy expression.

The other Guild members sensed something was wrong and exchanged glances. Then a single sentence turned their unease into reality.

"We'll set up a cordon here."

"What?"

"You mean a cordon? In this situation?"

"Guild Master, that's—"

Normally, the Guild members would have obeyed without complaint, but this time they protested. Won Myunghoon's eyes turned cold.

"Shut up and follow my orders. I have my reasons."

"Even so, this isn't right! We're dealing with a Named Monster—urk!"

Won Myunghoon seized the throat of the Guild member who had raised his voice the loudest and growled.

"You're disobeying the Guild Master's orders inside a Gate? Are you that desperate to die, you son of a bitch…?"

It happened in the blink of an eye.

The atmosphere froze. Everyone present knew Won Myunghoon's words weren't aimed at just one man.

They had watched him for years. They knew he was more than capable of carrying out his threat.

“I—I’m sorry.”

“This is your last chance. There won’t be another.”

Thud.

Won Myunghoon turned away from the Guild member, who collapsed to the ground with a white face, and swept his sharp gaze across the area.

“Fucking idiots.”

Even in the face of his unfiltered abuse, a dozen pairs of eyes remained fixed on the ground.

They had spent years dealing with Won Myunghoon. This was nothing new.

They had to be even more careful around him inside a Gate. He was an A-Rank Hunter—a powerhouse none of them could defeat even if they attacked him together.

“Do your brains not work? Do I look stupid enough to take on a Named Monster?”

The bowed heads slowly began to rise.

“Then…”

“We’ll deal with those losers.”

“You mean the Peace Guild?”

“By now, they should all be dead.”

While fleeing in a panic, they had heard the monster’s roar. Just hearing it had weakened their knees and sent chills down their spines. It was terror itself.

They hadn’t even seen what the creature looked like, and that was precisely why they were still alive.

How could five people possibly fight something like that? They must all be dead by now.

Every one of them shared that opinion.

Everyone except Won Myunghoon.

“What if even one of them survives and escapes?”

“Th—that…”

“No way.”

They hadn’t considered that possibility.

Under normal circumstances, they might have. But fear of the Named Monster and their desperate will to survive had paralyzed their minds.

Won Myunghoon addressed the hesitant Guild members in a firm voice.

“If even one of those losers gets out of the Gate alive, every last one of us is finished.”

“…”

“An A-Rank Hunter who’s been soaking up the media spotlight dies, and then one of the surviving Peace Guild members starts talking about us? I don’t need to explain what happens next, do I?”

The media’s attention—no, the entire country’s—would turn toward them.

Investigators would get involved. The press and broadcast media would treat it as a major story, churning out new reports day after day.

Even if the survivor couldn’t provide definitive testimony or physical evidence, the contempt and condemnation directed at them would never disappear.

They might even have to leave the country. They would be reduced to people who needed a visa just to visit their parents’ graves.

The thought alone was horrifying.

“Sometimes, what people believe matters more than the truth. You all learned that eight years ago, didn’t you?”

“Guild Master!”

“That’s—!”

The Star Guild members erupted in agitation.

It was an unspoken taboo, yet Won Myunghoon himself had brought it up.

Wasn’t he the one who had planned everything and recruited them in the first place?

At the Guild members’ hardened gazes, Won Myunghoon let out a quiet laugh.

“Eyes down, you fucking bastards. Before I rip them all out.”

“…!”

“You joined because you wanted to. Is there a single bastard here who didn’t take my money? You used it to buy houses and cars, drink and chase women, then got married and had kids. Now you’re all living comfortably, pretending to be good fathers and devoted husbands. Aren’t you?”

Won Myunghoon irritably ran a hand through his hair. Whenever his gleaming eyes swept over them, they trembled.

They wanted to deny it, but every word out of his mouth was true.

They had already crossed a river from which there was no return, and Won Myunghoon was the one who had ferried them to the other side.

The ferryman had already hidden the boat. Without his permission, they could never return to the opposite bank.

Not while they still drew breath.

“I won’t waste any more time talking. Hide and form a cordon. When I give the signal, be ready to kill anyone.”

Won Myunghoon’s voice, thick with killing intent, might as well have been a verdict handed down by the Supreme Court.

Realizing there would be no appeal, the Guild members scattered and began forming the cordon.

“Fucking idiots. It’s already been eight years…”

As Won Myunghoon spat the words through clenched teeth, one of the Guild members cautiously approached him.

“Guild Master.”

“What?”

“Team Leader 1, sir—I mean, what should we do with Team Leader 1?”

“Kim Jonghun? Where the hell is that bastard?”

“We moved him over there for now.”

Won Myunghoon turned his head in the direction the Guild member pointed and let out a hollow laugh.

Only a few meters[1202] away, Kim Jonghun was pale and clacking his teeth together. He looked like a man possessed.

“Pathetic bastard. I was the idiot for keeping something like that around and calling him an A-Rank Hunter.”

Won Myunghoon clicked his tongue softly and waved a hand.

“Handle it quietly.”

“What? I—I can’t!”

“What the hell does that mean?”

“I mean I won’t commit murder.”

“What? What the hell is going through that lunatic head of yours—wait.”

Won Myunghoon had been about to smack the Guild member when he suddenly stopped.

He had only meant for them to keep Jonghun quiet with Silence magic or whatever else was necessary.

But did they really need to?

Come to think of it, no one knows more about my secrets than he does.

He had used Jonghun as his right-hand man for a full ten years. The man had a certain low cunning, and his skills as a Hunter were excellent.

Even when that incident had occurred eight years ago, Won Myunghoon had believed that Team Leader 1, if no one else, would never betray him.

If he opened his mouth, he wouldn’t have gotten off unscathed either.

It wasn’t a matter of trust, but mutual interests.

The scale of their greed might differ, but in a sense, the two of them were cut from the same cloth.

But…

[1202] A few meters is roughly 2–5 m, or about 7–16 ft.

He's useless now.

Won Myunghoon had seen plenty of people exposed to the Fear of high-level monsters.

Their symptoms varied, but they all had one thing in common.

Junk.

Once fear had been branded into their souls, they could never return to the way they had been.

Some went mad and were locked away in special wards. Even those who managed to recover could consider their lives as Hunters over.

He knows more about my secrets than anyone, and he's the one who personally acquired Yeti's Necklace.

On top of that, his credentials as an A-Rank Hunter were now worth no more than the paper they were printed on.

Won Myunghoon deliberated only briefly, then reached his decision even faster.

"Tie him up. I have a use for him."

"What?"

"When that Named Monster comes, don't you think we'll need at least one piece of prey to throw to it?"

"…!"

"It works out well in more ways than one. Since Jin Taekyung is dead, we need to throw in an A-Rank Hunter from our side to make the story convincing."

Won Myunghoon patted the frozen Guild member on the shoulder as he passed, then concealed himself in the nearby undergrowth.

Come on. Anyone. Come.

He didn't have to wait long.

When he saw two people emerge through the undergrowth several dozen meters[1203] away, the corners of his mouth lifted.

The old Guild Master and Jin Taekyung. Are the others all dead?

Jin Taekyung was covered in blood from head to toe, with an old mage carried on his back.

No matter how Won Myunghoon looked at them, they resembled nothing so much as wounded survivors of a lost battle.

This should be easy.

Jin Taekyung in particular—Won Myunghoon wanted to kill that bastard with his own hands.

He had just finished preparing to signal the Guild members when—

"Come out, you fucking bastards."

[1203] Several dozen meters is roughly 30–70 m, or about 100–230 ft.

Jin Taekyung crooked a finger directly toward the undergrowth where Won Myunghoon was hiding.

The smile at Won Myunghoon's lips vanished without a trace.

"Would you look at this insolent bastard."

Seeing Won Myunghoon's twisted face, I couldn't help but laugh under my breath.

How should I put it? I felt like I'd just seen how low a human being could sink.

"You're laughing?"

Apparently, my reaction made him even angrier. He licked his dry lips and exhaled a hot breath.

"You bastard…do you not understand what kind of situation you're in?"

"I understand perfectly."

"And someone who understands the situation is grinning?"

"Choose your words carefully. Hearing you say that makes me want to split your head open."

"…What?"

"You should've stopped when I called you Mr. Won Myunghoon. Won Myunghoon, you fucking bastard."

The hyenas' faces went blank.

Won Myunghoon's lips remained tightly sealed for a long moment before finally opening.

"Have you lost your mind?"

"I'm as sane as ever. Aren't I, Butler Kim?"

Still on my back and watching the situation unfold, Butler Kim answered.

"Entirely normal. Never losing one's composure, no matter the situation, is one of the basic qualities a Hunter should possess."

"What about that bastard?"

"If this had happened during the Great Cataclysm, we wouldn't have found so much as his corpse. Those were somewhat rougher times."

"That's what he says."

Bang!

A single punch shattered a tree thick enough for a man to wrap both arms around.

Won Myunghoon's face flushed bright red as he glared at Butler Kim and me.

"You fucking bastards!"

"What a rude bastard. There's nothing he won't say to an elder, is there? Right?"

Butler Kim answered calmly.

“The young man does seem somewhat lacking in manners. But isn’t this a good world we live in? We should give him a chance.”

“Is that so?”

“Life is a series of choices. And from what I can see, you appear to have already made yours.”

“You’re a ghost.”

“I don’t particularly care for that word. I am somewhat advanced in age, after all.”

“Sorry. I didn’t mean anything by it.”

“I’ll get down first. One, two, three.”

Crack.

As Butler Kim hopped down from my back, the sound of a bone slipping out of place came from his knee.

“Oh dear, are you all right?”

“My knee has been troubling me. Heal.”

When the glow faded, he tapped his knee a few times and smiled.

“I’m fine now.”

“Wow.”

Magic really was incredibly convenient.

After letting out that exclamation, I turned my head toward the knife-like gazes stabbing in from every direction.

A dozen or so Star Guild members, including Won Myunghoon, were glaring at us as if they wanted to tear us apart and kill us.

“What the fuck are you trying to do?”

“What else? I helped him down. I thought he might get shaken around too much during the fight.”

“Fight?”

“What? Didn’t you come here to fight me?”

“Of course not.”

Won Myunghoon added with a savage laugh,

“We came to kill every last one of you.”

“Oh… You sound exactly like a villain in a web novel.”

I was fairly impressed.

At the same time, the last of my hesitation faded, and my mind became clear.

Right. I just had to do it.

“Thanks for saying that. My headache’s completely gone. Maybe you’re not a son of a bitch after all—maybe you’re Dogvorin.”[1204]

[1204] Gevorin is a Korean painkiller. Taekyung swaps its first syllable for the Korean word for “dog” to make a pun.

“You bastard!”

“Maybe not. Then let’s go?”

“…What?”

Whoosh!

I suddenly found myself wondering what expression Won Myunghoon was wearing.

But then I realized it didn’t matter.

Whatever expression he had worn until now, the one he was about to make had already been decided.

“Bear with the pain. No crying.”

Crack!

As he hurriedly turned and swung his arm, I caught it and twisted it.

The bone snapped in an instant. His grip went limp, and the spear slipped from his hand.

His smooth, unlined face twisted like a demon’s as a scream burst from his throat.

“Gyaaaaaaaaaah!”

“Didn’t I tell you?”

I continued in a calm voice.

“Never bare your teeth at me again.”

At the same time, I drove my tightly clenched fist into his maw.

Crunch!

Chapter 225

Crack!

With a grisly crunch, white teeth shot into the air.

He had taken such meticulous care of them that they gleamed even in the darkness. Not that it mattered anymore.

“Puh-haaaack!”

Thud!

Won Myunghoon flew several meters[1205] before slamming his back into a tree and coughing.

The teeth left in his mouth tumbled out with the blood. When he finally raised his head, his face was twisted in shock.

“H-How could this…”

It had all happened in the blink of an eye.

And it wasn’t only Won Myunghoon. Every Star Guild member stared at me in disbelief.

“What do you mean, how? I’m stronger than you. That’s how.”

“T-That can’t be.”

“Yeah. It can.”

I gave him a breezy answer and took a single step forward. Won Myunghoon began to tremble.

“Don’t come any closer!”

“Did I come looking for you? You’re the ones who were waiting for me.”

It was already too late to turn back. I intended to make sure they understood exactly what happened when they bared their teeth at me.

Perhaps sensing the danger, Won Myunghoon shrieked as if having a fit.

“What are you waiting for, you bastards?”

“G-Guild Master.”

“There are only two of them! If we back down now, every last one of us is going to die!”

The hesitant Star Guild members raised their weapons at his command. Won Myunghoon gritted the few teeth he had left.

“I’ll handle this bastard. Get the old man first!”

I stopped.

“What did you just say?”

“Why? Did I hit a nerve?”

Won Myunghoon snorted and glared at me with blazing eyes.

[1205] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

“Jin Taekyung, you bastard. I don’t know what kind of bullshit trick you pulled, but it ends here.”

“Bullshit trick?”

“Don’t play dumb. You obviously found some high-performance acceleration Equipment somewhere and put it on…”

“Oh, that’s what you meant?”

My eyes widened in surprise.

Won Myunghoon’s imagination was impressive. He had somehow managed to rationalize his defeat.

“That’s a pretty original theory. But isn’t the hostage routine a little cliché by comparison?”

“It may be cliché, but the important thing is that it always works.”

“I don’t know about that…”

I let my voice trail off.

While Won Myunghoon and I exchanged those few words, the Star Guild members charged toward Butler Kim with their tanks leading the way.

“I think things might be a little different this time.”

“What?”

The moment Won Myunghoon questioned me, Butler Kim—who had been massaging his lower back—drove his long staff into the ground.

It was a light movement. Yet the power flowing from the tip of his staff shook the earth.

Then his deep voice rang out, like the final switch on a bomb.

“Turn it upside down. Earthquake.”

Rumble!

The primeval forest convulsed.

Cracks split the solid ground. Dirt and rocks shot into the air, exposing the trunks of trees that had sunk their roots deep into the earth. Flocks of nameless birds took flight.

—Screeeech!

They were the only ones able to escape the earthquake.

Unfortunately for the Star Guild members, they had no wings. The cracked and shattered ground surged up like triangular waves and swallowed them whole.

“Everyone, get out of the—urk!”

“Gyaaaaaaah!”

Rooooar!

Once the waves had swept past, only scattered groans and screams drifted through the forest.

The Star Guild members lay crushed beneath an enormous weight of earth and rubble, barely managing to keep their heads exposed as they gasped for breath.

The man who had incapacitated around a dozen veteran B-Rank Hunters with a single spell could not have looked more at ease.

“Young men these days have no respect for their Senior. Stop struggling and close your eyes, all of you—unless you want to be buried alive.”

His voice was chilling, unlike anything I had ever heard from him before.

Only then did the Star Guild members realize the true extent of Butler Kim’s abilities. Their faces went pale, and they lowered their heads.

Well, except for one person.

“An A-Rank mage…!”

A-Rank Hunters were rare, but A-Rank mages and healers were rarer still. The Star Guild members had probably never expected Butler Kim—who always kept his hands folded behind his back and laughed amiably—to be an A-Rank mage.

I grinned at the trembling Won Myunghoon.

“The hostage situation failed. What are you going to do now?”

“…”

“That’s why I told you not to bare your teeth.”

Won Myunghoon had been standing there blankly, as if his soul had left his body. At last, he managed to speak.

“What are you? What are all of you?”

“You already know. We’re the Peace Guild. We’d like to live up to our name, but no one around us seems willing to cooperate.”

Won Myunghoon bit his lip.

He could never have imagined that one bad decision would lead to this.

But it was already too late to turn back. A cornered hyena had only two choices left.

Run. Or submit.

Won Myunghoon chose the latter.

Clang!

The spear slipped from his hand and rolled across the ground.

“…I surrender.”

“You surrender?”

I walked toward him. When I kicked the fallen spear far away, he lowered his head in resignation.

“Just like that?”

“…”

Even with me standing right in front of him, he didn’t move. I addressed him as he stood there silently with his head bowed.

“Once we get out, you’re looking at life in prison at the very least. You know how serious a crime this is inside a Gate, don’t you?”

After a moment’s hesitation, Won Myunghoon spoke.

“Because it’s better than dying.”

“Better than dying… Yeah, that’s true.”

As long as he survived, there would still be a chance. Death, on the other hand, meant a complete end. Whatever lay beyond it was something he would only discover afterward.

People with a lot to lose tended to fear death. Won Myunghoon was no exception.

“Raise your head.”

“…All right.”

I stared into his eyes.

An unknowable light swirled within those twin pupils, dark as the abyss.

Fear of the future awaiting him. Anxiety over death.

And then…

Thump!

“Taekyung. Please.”

“…”

“Just once. Give me one last chance. Killing someone like me will only leave a bad taste in your mouth.”

“It’ll leave a bad taste, but you won’t be punished. If you’re threatened with murder in a Gate, self-defense is recognized. You know that too.”

“B-But still.”

Won Myunghoon swallowed hard.

“If you kill me, it’s murder. That doesn’t change the fact that you’ll become a murderer.”

Murderer.

The word rolling around on the tip of my tongue left a foul taste.

I looked down at Won Myunghoon, kneeling before me and begging for his life in a servile voice, then spoke.

“I’ll trust you.”

“Taekyung!”

“But do me a favor. Don’t betray that trust.”

I tossed him a rope and told him to bind himself. The moment I turned away—

“Ha-ha-ha! You stupid bastard!”

A triumphant shout rang out, and killing intent flared behind me.

I turned my head. Won Myunghoon was already right on top of me, an Aura-infused dagger clutched in his hand.

“Die!”

Whoosh! Slash!

A brief rush of displaced air—and a fountain of blood sprayed upward. The triumphant joy lighting Won Myunghoon’s face gave way to bewilderment.

“…Huh?”

Thud.

A moment later, something fell to the ground.

It was Won Myunghoon’s wrist, cleanly severed and still clutching the dagger whose Aura had vanished.

“You needed to be at least twice that fast.”

I flicked the blood from the dagger in my hand. In that split second, I had drawn a weapon from my Inventory, and the fight had ended just as quickly.

A brief silence followed, though it felt like an eternity.

Then Won Myunghoon’s mouth slowly fell open, and a horrific scream burst from it.

“Gyaaaaaaaaaah!”

As I watched him writhe in agony, my heart remained as still and peaceful as a lake.

I felt no betrayal at having trusted someone I should never have trusted. Not even the slightest regret.

Because…

“Thanks. You did exactly what I trusted you to do.”

I had never trusted Won Myunghoon in the first place.

Not since I received Yeti’s Necklace. Not since the moment he ignored my warning and bared his teeth at me again.

“You were always exactly this kind of man.”

“Urgh, gyaaaaah!”

“If I leave you alive, you’ll bare your teeth at me again someday. Like a thorn stuck in my throat, you’ll find some way to come back as long as you survive.”

Slice. Slice.

My dagger severed the tendons in his calf. Blood spattered, and his knee buckled. Just as I pressed the razor-sharp blade against his throat—

“Hunter Jin Taekyung!”

Several dozen meters[1206] away, Butler Kim was watching me with concern in his eyes.

“There is no need to go that far.”

“You’re right. That’s why I let him go once.”

[1206] Several dozen meters is roughly 100–200 ft.

“But killing a monster and murdering a person are different. I would rather do it myself—”

I answered calmly.

“I know.”

“…Pardon?”

“I know that perfectly well.”

How many people had I killed by now? Dozens? No, a hundred?

The world I had lived in had never been forgiving. In Gates, I had to kill monsters. In the Murim, I had to kill people.

I was no lofty junzi.[1207] I was a Hunter and a martial artist with a family and people I had to protect. If surviving and becoming stronger meant getting blood on my hands, I would do it willingly.

To me, there was little difference between a monster and Won Myunghoon.

Because he’s an enemy.

Whoever the enemy might be, if they could someday bring harm to me or my people, the right thing to do was eliminate the threat at its source.

“So don’t stop me.”

“…!”

Butler Kim had fought his way through countless battlefields himself.

That brief exchange must have been enough for him to understand what kind of person I was—and what I had decided to do.

He regarded me with a grave look, then gave a small nod.

“Urgh. P-Please, spare me…”

“Spare you?”

I looked down at the groaning Won Myunghoon.

He had once been the idol I looked up to as a child—the man who shone brighter than anyone among countless stars.

But now I would seal those old memories inside a time capsule and bury them deep underground.

I whispered quietly.

“If you were going to kill someone, you should’ve been prepared to die.”

“Ta-Taekyung. Please…”

Slice!

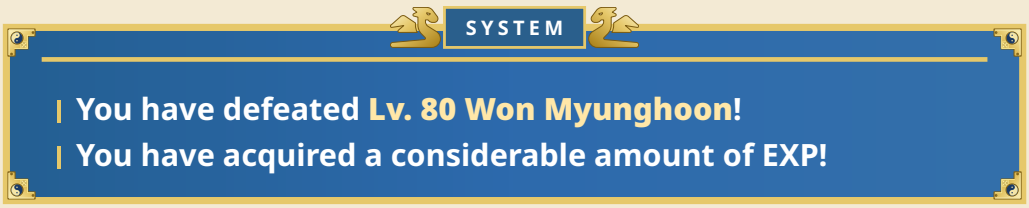
The dagger cut deep into his throat. Won Myunghoon’s eyes bulged as he stared up at me pleadingly.

He tried to cover the wound with his one remaining hand, but he could stop neither the blood nor his life from pouring out.

[1207] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

Grrrgh. Thud.

The moment his body collapsed with a wet, rattling gurgle—



The System announced the enemy's death.

"Let's go."

Butler Kim nodded as he watched me with a strange look in his eyes.

"We have more baggage to take with us now."

He waved his staff, and the Star Guild members buried beneath the earth floated gently into the air.

As I watched magical ropes being summoned and binding them tightly together like strings of dried fish, I suddenly spoke.

"Wait a moment, Butler Kim."

"…?"

"We need to add one more person."

A short while later, I followed my Qi Sense and found a gagged man.

For some reason, he had been bound tightly to a tree. And I recognized his face.

"The Star Guild's Team One Leader?"

Most of the reporters who had flocked to cover the joint raid by the Peace Guild and the Star Guild—or rather, Jin Taekyung and Won Myunghoon's raid—had left long ago.

But there were always exceptions. One was a young man in thick, horn-rimmed glasses, eating ramen.[1208]

"Being the youngest is miserable. Just miserable."

His colleague snickered and picked up a piece of instant kimchi.[1209]

"You've only been here two months, and you already have plenty to say."

"Come on, Senior. You haven't been here that long either."

"Hey. Back in my day, I kept my mouth shut and worked. If they told me to stay, I stayed. If they told me to do something, I did it."

"But isn't this a bit much? How can they make us wait around for days just to cover one Hunter?"

[1208] Korean ramen, or *ramyeon*, is typically instant noodles.

[1209] *Kimchi* is a Korean dish of salted, fermented vegetables, commonly cabbage.

"You haven't changed since college. If you don't like it, stick around long enough to build up some seniority."

The young man stared glumly into his cup ramen,[1210] where beads of oil floated across the surface.

"It's an A-Rank Gate. It'll take at least three days for them to come out…"

"Three days? We should count ourselves lucky if they don't stay the whole week."

"A week?"

"It's an A-Rank Gate. Once they're inside, they might as well get everything they can out of it."

"…Ugh."

The young man shuddered as if the mere thought gave him goose bumps.

Seeing groups of other junior reporters in the same miserable situation eating nearby only made him feel worse.

"I wish they'd come out soon."

"They definitely won't be out today. Like you said, even if they're quick, it'll still take three days. Get some sleep. Want to hit a sauna together? Maybe play some billiards?"

"Billiards?"

"Yeah. There's plenty to do around here. The local businesses just rip you off."

"Then maybe one game of billiards…"

Tempted by his Senior's offer, the young reporter had just begun to rise when—

Whoooooosh.

The enormous door looming before them—the Gate—gave off a strange sound.

The mana that had lain as still as the surface of a lake began to swirl, and urgent shouts erupted from every direction.

"The Gate! The Gate is opening!"

"Already? What the hell?"

"The cameras! Get them over here, now!"

The area fell into chaos in an instant. The reporters who had been idly passing the time shot to their feet and crowded in front of the Gate.

The young reporter and his Senior were no exception. They claimed a spot at the front faster than anyone else, their minds reeling.

"What's going on? Why are they coming out already?"

"How should I know? Set up the equipment!"

Cameras began rolling, and flashes burst without pause.

The reporters had sensed that something had happened, and their prediction proved exactly right.

[1210] Korean ramen, or *ramyeon*, is typically instant noodles.

Whoosh!
Around a dozen people burst from the swirling vortex of mana.
Everyone who saw them stared with their mouths hanging open.
“…W-What happened?”

Chapter 226

Click, click!

A barrage of camera flashes blinded me. You'd think I would have gotten used to it by now, but apparently I really was a caterpillar that had to eat pine needles.[1211]

"Mr. Jin Taekyung! Did you clear the Gate?"

"If not, why did you come out so quickly?"

Questions rained down from the reporters. If the Gate security guards hadn't been there, they looked ready to jam their microphones into my mouth already.

But the initial frenzy soon died down, and confused voices rose to fill the void.

"But… why is Jin Taekyung covered in blood like that?"

"The numbers don't add up, either. The people behind him are Star Guild members."

"They're even tied up."

"Where's Won Myunghoon? I don't see him, either!"

I could more or less imagine how we looked on camera.

There was me, drenched in the blood of monsters and Won Myunghoon. A dozen or so Star Guild members tied together in a line. And Butler Kim holding the rope as though he were walking a dog.

I can't blame them for reacting like that.

I licked my dry lips, then shook my head at Butler Kim as he started to step forward on my behalf.

He had tried to stop me, and I had refused. This had happened because of my choice, so it was only right that I deal with the aftermath myself.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung! What happened?"

"Please, just give us one comment!"

The confused murmuring didn't last long. The moment the reporters caught the scent of a scoop, they went wild.

I calmly watched the frenzied press corps before asking the young reporter at the front a question. He wore thick, horn-rimmed glasses.

"Who do you work for?"

The young man flinched.

"Pardon? M-Me?"

"Yes. You."

"Uh, well, I…"

[1211] A Korean saying that a caterpillar should eat pine needles means a person should stick to what suits them.

He had been shouting the loudest from the front, but apparently hadn’t expected anything like this to happen.

After a brief panic, he finally managed to answer.

“H-HunterTV.”

“Oh. Them.”

HunterTV was a channel that focused on Hunter-related issues and information.

It was a cable channel, but it was also a major broadcaster whose ratings surpassed those of terrestrial networks.

Since it was connected to what I was about to say, both the reporter and I were lucky.

“I’ll take your questions.”

“Pardon?”

“There are too many microphones. I’d rather focus on one.”

“So… an exclusive?”

“Call it whatever you want. Shall we begin?”

He looked like a greenhorn, but a reporter was still a reporter.

The bewilderment vanished from his face, and his eyes gleamed behind his glasses.

“How about broadcasting it live?”

“Live?”

“Yes. Like at the Association last time. We can stream it in real time.”

A live stream.

After a moment’s thought, I nodded.

“Let’s do that.”

iTube was the number-one video-sharing website.

Countless channels, belonging to everyone from individuals to major organizations, were registered on the platform. Among them, HunterTV was a massive channel with several million subscribers in Korea alone.

At the same moment, the phones of HunterTV subscribers going about their daily lives all buzzed with the same notification.

Bzzzz.

[HunterTV has started a live stream.]

[“Jin Taekyung Exclusive Live Broadcast.”]

The view count hit 100,000 in no time.

The sudden influx of viewers had left the screen black, but the chat was already blazing like a furnace packed with firewood.

> ㄴ What is this? Why is there suddenly an exclusive Jin Taekyung live broadcast?
> ㄴ No idea. Feels like it hasn't even been a day since Lord Fuck entered the Gate.
> ㄴ It's an A-Rank Gate. He's already out?
> ㄴ This buffering is absolute garbage.
> ㄴ Now I want some Butter Rings.[1212]
> ㄴ Oh, the picture's up.
> ㄴ Everyone shut up and welcome Lord Fuck with the proper reverence.

Pop.

The brief but seemingly endless buffering finally ended, and the video began to play.

The moment the viewers saw the enormous Gate and the young man standing before it, their fingers flew across their screens.

> ㄴ It's Lord Fuck!
> ㄴ Oh my god, fuck.
> ㄴ Please insult me!
> ㄴ Smack my ass, too!
> ㄴ Cut it out, you lunatics.

Jin Taekyung's popularity was through the roof.

He had saved countless lives by suppressing a B-Rank Gate. His approachable, down-to-earth demeanor, unexpected from an A-Rank Hunter, and even the bizarre spectacle of him accidentally swearing during an official press conference had kept him at the center of attention day after day.

But the excitement didn't last long. The viewers soon noticed that something was wrong.

> ㄴ Why does he look like that?
> ㄴ Did Lord Fuck get hurt? He's covered in blood.
> ㄴ Half the people are missing, too. And the ones there are tied up;;
> ㄴ What the hell is this? Something happened.
> ㄴ What's HunterTV doing? If you started a broadcast, at least ask some questions.

[1212] Butter Rings are Korean butter cookies. Their Korean name, *beoteoring*, sounds like *beopeoring*, the Korean pronunciation of "buffering."

Perhaps mindful of the chaos in the chat, the HunterTV reporter finally spoke.

“I’ll get straight to the point. What happened inside the Gate?”

“It would take too long to explain everything from beginning to end… Is it all right if I summarize?”

“Please do.”

Vrrrrr.

The camera zoomed in until Jin Taekyung’s face filled the screen.

His face was smeared with blood and dust, but his eyes shone calmly. Then a composed voice flowed between his parted lips.

“There was a Named Monster.”

“…!”

“It was a Mutated Gate.”

In an instant, the noise at the scene vanished as though someone had pressed the mute button.

The chat froze for a moment, then began racing upward.

> ㄴ ??
>
> ㄴ ???
>
> ㄴ Wait, why is there a Named Monster here;;;
>
> ㄴ They must all be dead. No wonder so many people are missing;;
>
> ㄴ Is Won Myunghoon dead, too? I haven’t seen him since earlier;
>
> ㄴ Holy shit…

A major incident.

The same words flashed through everyone’s minds.

Even the reporter holding the microphone out to Jin Taekyung forgot his job and stood there with his mouth hanging open.

A Named Monster.

Everyone knew the kind of destruction one could cause.

Five years earlier, a Named Monster that appeared in Central and South America had possessed enough power to destroy a small city by itself.

Although it had finally been defeated after several days of fighting, the damage had been enormous.

Hundreds of Hunters had died, along with ten times as many civilians.

The incident had drawn the attention of the entire world. There wasn’t a reporter or viewer who hadn’t heard of it.

> ㄴ If it really was a Named Monster, surviving was a miracle;

> ㄴ No. Wait a second.
> ㄴ Then that means there's still a Named Monster inside the Gate;;;
> ㄴ So what? It's inside the Gate. Isn't it fine?
> ㄴ Did this bastard just get here from Mars? You idiot, don't you know what happens when the mana level exceeds a Gate's capacity? The monsters come pouring out.
> ㄴ That catastrophe in Central and South America a few years ago happened because the mana level exceeded the limit and the Gate opened;;
> ㄴ The Black Wyvern's Nest? Does anyone know where that is?
> ㄴ Holy shit;; Get the reporters out of there first.

The reporters who had been staring back and forth between Jin Taekyung and the chat as if hypnotized suddenly snapped out of it.

"A Named Monster!"

"Hey, get out of here right now! Grab the cameras!"

No scoop was worth more than their lives.

Just as the reporters, sensing the threat of death, began wading into chaos, someone who had been watching the entire situation finally spoke.

"Ah, I already took down the raid monster, so you don't have to worry too much."

His clear voice rang in everyone's ears.

The reporters who had been trying to flee in a panic and the viewers staring at their phone screens while swallowing nervously both wondered if they had heard correctly.

"Pardon?"

"…What did you say?"

> ㄴ ????
> ㄴ I think I heard that wrong.
> ㄴ What did Lord Fuck just say?
> ㄴ He says he killed a Named Monster…?
> ㄴ Who did?
> ㄴ Lord Fuck.
> ㄴ What did he kill?
> ㄴ A Named Monster.
> ㄴ Can he even do that?
> ㄴ I don't know…

The camera, which had been shaking as though caught in an earthquake, steadied and refocused. Dozens of cameras turned toward the young man's perfectly calm face.

The reporter in horn-rimmed glasses asked Jin Taekyung in a trembling voice,

"C-Could you say that one more time?"

"It's just as I said."

"Then you really killed the Named Monster…"

"Yes. I killed it."

He killed it? A Named Monster?

Everyone's jaws dropped at the unbelievable words that had come from Jin Taekyung's mouth. One reporter finally recovered enough to blurt out a question.

"T-Then did the others die in the process?"

"Seven people died. The rest are safe…"

His voice trailed off. After thinking for a moment, he continued in the same unwavering tone.

"Oh, I should add Won Myunghoon to the death toll. That makes eight."

"W-Won Myunghoon? Why did he…"

"Uh, well…"

Jin Taekyung hesitated briefly before adding,

"I got him."

"…Pardon?"

"Ah, not got. I killed—no, that sounds strange, too. Give me a moment."

Before the aftershock of the Named Monster bomb had even faded, a second bomb went off.

The dozens of reporters at the scene and the 100,000 viewers watching the screen were left half dazed.

What the hell is he talking about?

At the exact moment the same thought crossed everyone's mind, Jin Taekyung finally found what he considered the most appropriate expression.

"This is probably the best way to put it. I 'disposed of him.'"

"…"

"…"

At the end of the heavy silence, a single new line appeared in the frozen chat.

> ㄴ Did this guy just come back from sorting recyclables at home?

Everything moved swiftly from there. The emergency investigation team dug into the truth of the incident with speed and precision.

Countless eyes were on the case. If they missed even a single detail, they might receive a lifetime's worth of abuse.

"Handle this properly. Miss even one thing and you're finished—finished!"

"This has already been reported all the way to the Blue House.[1213] If we slip up, we're all going over the cliff together."

Both the government and the Hunter Association's leadership were on edge.

Contrary to their fears, however, it didn't take long for the whole truth to come to light.

"Holy shit… He killed this thing by himself?"

"He actually killed it."

The investigators were stunned when they confirmed that the enormous Named Monster lay gruesomely dead.

By then, every Star Guild member who had participated in the raid was tied to a cold metal chair in an interrogation room.

"I don't know anything."

"Look, Hunter. The truth will come out soon enough. Why make this difficult?"

"I'm telling you, I don't know anything."

"Ha, you bastard… You'd spill everything with one mental spell, but you still have to be annoying."

"Did you just swear at me? You think being a prosecutor means you can do whatever you want? And don't you know mental magic is illegal?"

Their lives were on the line. They couldn't give up the comfortable lives they had enjoyed as B-Rank Hunters and rot in prison for the rest of their days.

The prosecutors were racking their brains over the Star Guild members' stubborn denials when an unexpected savior appeared.

"I-I'll tell you everything."

Kim Jonghun, Team 1 Leader of the Star Guild, was still mentally shaken when he confessed to everything that had happened.

It was a perfect testimony. On top of that, an anonymous informant had sent a USB drive and a note.

> The Hapsburphon family, a long-established German family of equipment makers, has produced rare and highly practical items. One of their representative products is the PSV-96K camera, which cannot be detected by

[1213] The Blue House was the South Korean presidential office.

> any detection magic and functions normally even in Gates with unstable mana…

The prosecutor in charge stared incredulously at the note before asking the investigator,

“What is this supposed to mean?”

“They filmed the entire raid. There’s footage on the USB. Open it and you’ll see. That bastard Won Myunghoon was a real piece of shit.”

“Filming is illegal, isn’t it?”

“It is.”

“It was the Peace Guild, right?”

“Wouldn’t you say so?”

“…”

“Let that much slide. Every Guild with enough clout does it. They didn’t leak it to civilians, and thanks to them, we secured conclusive physical evidence. We both benefit from this…”

Bang!

An employee burst through the door and thrust out his phone.

“H-Have you seen this?”

The number-one real-time search term was boldly displayed across the screen:

“Won Myunghoon Raid Footage Leaked.”

As the ugly side of a former star people remembered fondly was revealed, the internet boiled like a cauldron over hot coals.

> └ What a fucking bastard.
>
> └ My head is ringing. Is this really true? It’s not staged, is it?
>
> └ Good riddance. Taekyung was right to kill him.
>
> └ Still, it was clearly murder. Did he really have to kill Won Myunghoon…?
>
> └ Myunghoon, is that you?
>
> └ Does Wi-Fi reach hell?
>
> └ Did Yama[1214] turn on his hotspot for you?
>
> └ You’re calling this murder? Have you never heard of self-defense?

Only two days had passed since the incident. Yet the backlash was fiercer than anything people could remember.

Each time another long-buried suspicion about Won Myunghoon came to light, public fury boiled over anew.

[1214] Yama is a ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

And after every wave of still-smoldering rage had swept through, the discussion always ended with the same question.

> └ So what is Jin Taekyung doing?
> └ At this hour? Probably sleeping.
> └ Probably sorting recyclables.

Chapter 227

“Thank you for all your hard work.”

A man in a rumpled suit held out his hand.

His skin was dry and his eyes were sunken. Apparently, the investigator hadn’t been exaggerating when he said the man hadn’t been home in a week.

“You’re the one who worked hard, Prosecutor. Me? Not really.”

I shook hands with the prosecutor in charge and looked around.

The spacious room had a soft bed, a sofa, and even a state-of-the-art wall-mounted TV.

When I was first summoned by the prosecutors’ office, I had imagined a cold, dark interrogation room. Instead, they had put me up in a hotel suite.

“I didn’t expect to be treated this well.”

“The higher-ups are very interested in this case. Would you mind if I sat down for a moment?”

“Oh, sure.”

“Thank you.”

The prosecutor answered wearily and collapsed onto the sofa.

“There was some debate, to be honest. We had quite an argument over whether your actions constituted self-defense or excessive force.”

That part had been bothering me, too.

I had killed Won Myunghoon when I could have subdued him. It went beyond the bounds of self-defense.

Of course, even if I went back a week, I would make the same choice.

“So I assume the issue was resolved in my favor?”

“Of course. Do you think I would’ve come alone otherwise? I would’ve brought Hunters from the Ministry of Justice.”

The prosecutor spoke jokingly, but then his eyes fell on the morning paper lying on the table.

The Black Wyvern’s carcass filled nearly the entire front page. He eyed it and smacked his lips.

“Though even if I had brought them, they probably wouldn’t have been much help.”

“I’m a model citizen. The kind who could live just fine without laws.”

“There was a movie called *Law Abiding Citizen*. The protagonist killed a prosecutor and even a judge.”

“…”

What was this? Was he asking me to hit him?

The prosecutor let out a quiet laugh at my expression and stood.

“I should get going. I have an incredible backlog of work.”

“I’m glad I could lend a hand.”

“You didn’t lend a hand. You created the work. Once we started digging, every lead pulled up another, like sweet-potato vines.”

I had suspected that Won Myunghoon had plenty of skeletons in his closet.

But once the investigation began in earnest, so much filth came pouring out of his past that I found myself wondering what kind of bastard he had been.

Among his countless crimes were several cases similar to what had happened a week ago.

The incident eight years ago was no different.

Won Myunghoon had been a monster created by the media.

When his brief burst of popularity faded and the spotlight moved on, he tried to stir up scandals himself to draw the public’s attention back to him.

But in the process, the most popular star Hunter of the time died. Under suspicion from the Association and uneasy scrutiny from the public, Won Myunghoon quietly faded from memory.

“He covered up everything thoroughly. With money, with power, and sometimes by making people disappear in what looked like Gate accidents.”

Naturally, there had also been extensive lobbying to minimize the incidents.

In the end, the political and business figures connected to him had to appear before the cameras in wheelchairs and masks.

Along with their favorite line:

I will cooperate fully with the investigation.

Whether the investigation would be conducted properly, or whether they would cooperate in good faith, remained to be seen. But one thing was certain.

The prosecutor spoke with conviction.

“At least half of them are going down.”

The wildfire was already spreading out of control. Putting it out would take more than uprooting a weed or two.

Won Myunghoon’s death had only been the beginning.

“I hope that’s what happens.”

“It has to. It will.”

He offered what sounded like a farewell and reached for the doorknob. Then he paused and turned around.

“I’ve been so busy that I forgot to say this.”

“…?”

His previously straight back bent in a deep bow.

“Thank you. All of this is thanks to you, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

I'm a simple man. I killed the raid monster because I had a grudge to settle, and I killed Won Myunghoon because he was my enemy.

But the world called me a hero who had prevented a major catastrophe and brought justice.

It was a little burdensome, but…

Well, this isn't so bad either.

I smiled and nodded. A faint smile crossed the prosecutor's exhausted face.

I followed the investigator I had gotten to know over the past week down to the basement.

"You don't need to worry. Security is airtight."

Just as he had said, there wasn't a reporter—or even a camera—in sight in the underground parking lot.

Instead, some familiar faces were waiting for me.

"Son!"

"Oppa!"[1215]

Two people rushed at me with shrieks, and I hugged them both.

No, let me correct that. I hugged Mom and pushed Hayeon away with my palm.

"Son! Are you all right? You're not hurt anywhere?"

"I'm fine. Just a few scratches."

Looking as if she'd just had ten years scared off her life, Mom ran her hands over my entire body. Then she sucked in a breath.

"S-Scratches? Where? You're hurt?"

"No, I misspoke."

"You said you got scratched!"

"I said I wanted some of your *saengchae muchim*.[1216] The words just came out wrong."

"Taekyung, you're lying again, aren't you? You fought a terrifying monster like that. How could you not have a single injury?"

"It was big, but it was a gentle kid."

"Son, are you going to keep playing word games? Mom is being serious, so hurry up and take off your clothes."

"…How am I supposed to do that here? This is driving me crazy."

I had the reflexes to dodge bullets, but somehow I couldn't evade Mom's hands.

[1215] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses to address an older brother or an older man she is close to.

[1216] *Saengchae muchim* is a seasoned raw-vegetable dish. *Saengchae* sounds similar to the Korean word for "scratch."

Had she learned a grappling technique or something?

As I struggled helplessly, my household-register mate with the other set of chromosomes asked with a shocked expression,

"…Why did I get pushed away?"

"You really have to ask?"

"I'm asking because I don't know."

"Then you deserve a hit."

Flick!

"Ow! Mom! Oppa[1217] hit me!"

"Can't either of you behave?"

Hayeon clutched her forehead with a wounded expression while Mom shouted at us.

In the middle of the chaos, I noticed someone watching us with a smile.

"Don't just stand there smiling. Please stop them."

"Isn't this proof that your family is close? I'm actually jealous."

His legs were long and straight, like a model's. He looked as though he had just stepped out of a magazine shoot as he gripped my shoulder firmly.

"You've been through a lot, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"You too, Team Leader Choi."

But where was everyone else?

Team Leader Choi noticed me looking around and spoke.

"They all wanted to come, but I stopped them. There are too many eyes watching us."

"Oh."

"Reporters are camped out everywhere. I'll take you home first. We can talk on the way."

An underground parking lot wasn't exactly the best place to catch up. Especially not with a prosecutor's investigator watching us.

We climbed into a high-end sedan with heavily tinted windows. The car purred pleasantly as it wound through the forest of skyscrapers.

"A great deal happened while you were being questioned, though I assume you know most of it."

"I saw it all on TV. I turned off my phone because I was getting so many calls."

Network TV, cable, radio.

These days, wherever I turned, I heard my name and Won Myunghoon's.

Politics, the economy, the Hunter industry—the whole country was in an uproar.

[1217] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses to address an older brother or an older man she is close to.

I've heard it so much I'm sick of it.

Even the national anthem got tiring after the second verse.

Team Leader Choi glanced at my expression and smiled.

"There's one important thing I should tell you."

"It's not about what we're having for dinner, is it?"

"No. It's related to what happened."

"Team Leader, please. I'm begging you."

"It concerns the processing of the Named Monster's byproducts."

"Please tell me. I'm begging you."

"…"

I sat up straight in the passenger seat and gazed at Team Leader Choi with sparkling eyes.

Mom and Hayeon, sitting in the back, perked up their ears as well.

"Byproducts? Are they really that important?"

"Mom, what are you, someone from the Korean Empire?[1218] Of course they're incredibly important!"

"Oh, please. Mom knows that much. I just don't have any idea how important…"

Plenty of products made from monster byproducts had been commercialized, but they were still luxuries reserved for the wealthy.

To Mom, who had spent her entire life tightening her belt, they might as well have belonged to another world.

As Mom trailed off, Team Leader Choi explained in a gentle voice.

"It depends on the monster. But in the case of the Named Monster Mr. Jin Taekyung killed, its value is astronomical."

"R-Really? I only saw it in photographs, but it did look terrifying."

"As you saw, it was an extremely powerful monster. That's why it was valued at three hundred billion won.[1219]"

"Oh, I see."

A brief silence followed Mom's answer.

There wasn't even the sound of breathing. In the complete silence, I blinked without a word, then barely managed to speak.

"How much?"

"Three hundred billion won.[1220]"

Team Leader Choi added in the same calm tone,

"Oh, that's the auction's starting price."

"T-The starting price?"

[1218] The Korean Empire existed from 1897 to 1910; Taekyung is teasing Mom for sounding out of touch.

[1219] Three hundred billion won is about $210 million or €190 million.

[1220] Three hundred billion won is about $210 million or €190 million.

"Yes. The processing was completed three days ago, and Christie's has already…"

"Wait. Who's Christie?"

Hayeon stared at me in disbelief.

"What do you mean, who's Christie? You don't know Christie's?"

What an idiot. And he's my brother.

That was exactly what her expression said.

I racked my brain to preserve my authority as her older brother, but the only thing the name Christie brought to mind was a beautiful blonde woman.

"A-American billionaire's daughter?"

"…"

"O-Or someone from Hong Kong? European royalty? A Hollywood actress…"

Team Leader Choi came to my rescue as I broke into a cold sweat.

"It's a famous auction house. Along with Sotheby's, it competes for the top position in the industry."

"Oh."

Maybe I had heard of it. Or maybe I hadn't.

I had spent my childhood doing nothing but exercising and my adulthood working like an ox. How was I supposed to know about things like that?

Team Leader Choi, who was knowledgeable about such matters, continued smoothly.

"Christie's approached us first. They offered to charge a much lower commission than Sotheby's if we entrusted the auction to them."

"S-So?"

"Christie's appraisers assessed the value of the byproducts. At present, the starting price is three hundred billion won.[1221] Since the decision requires your consent, we've put off finalizing it."

Was this really happening?

I sat there dazed with my mouth hanging open, then smacked Hayeon on the forehead as she poked her head between the driver's and passenger's seats.

Smack!

"Ow!"

"It's real."

"Why did you hit me?"

"Because I'm precious."

Only after hearing her scream did it finally sink in.

Before long, I would be an incredibly wealthy man.

[1221] Three hundred billion won is about $210 million or €190 million.

"S-Son, what does this mean? Three hundred billion won?[1222]"

"Calm down. It's not all mine."

I didn't know how high the final bid would go, but the Hunter industry had clear rules for dividing the proceeds. Raids were team efforts, after all.

Even if I had killed it entirely by myself, the same principle applied.

But Team Leader Choi's next words left me stunned.

"It's your share, Mr. Jin Taekyung. Every last won."

"…Pardon?"

"The others all agreed. So I hope you won't say anything more about it."

"They all agreed?"

They could each have received anywhere from several billion won[1223] at the low end to tens of billions of won[1224] at the high end.

For an ordinary person, it would have been an irresistible temptation—and clearly their right to claim.

As I stared at him in shock, Team Leader Choi smoothly turned the steering wheel and replied,

"Neither I nor the others are shameless enough to take money for standing around and watching. We have at least that much conscience and conviction."

"You really didn't have to go that far…"

"It wasn't something that required any consideration. You've shown us enough consideration already, so think about what you want to do with the money."

Team Leader Choi's firm words left me speechless.

Three hundred billion won.[1225] Christie's auction.

The words swirled through my head, leaving my thoughts in chaos. Mom and Hayeon had been frozen like statues for a while now, so they were probably even worse off.

This is surreal.

I rubbed my stiff face with one palm.

An unimaginable fortune would soon come rolling into my hands. What should I do with it?

One fantasy led to another. A private jet, a luxury yacht, bundles of cash stacked like mountains, a leopard wearing a collar…

Before long, every one of those fantasies faded like fog.

Only then did my head clear. I finally knew what I should do with the money, and I could see the world around me clearly again.

[1222] Three hundred billion won is about $210 million or €190 million.

[1223] Several billion won is roughly 2–9 billion won, or about $1.4–6.4 million or €1.3–5.8 million.

[1224] Tens of billions of won is roughly 10–90 billion won, or about $7.1–64 million or €6.5–58 million.

[1225] Three hundred billion won is about $210 million or €190 million.

“Team Leader Choi.”
“Yes?”
“May I ask you for a favor?”
The corner of Team Leader Choi’s mouth lifted slightly.
“Anything.”

Chapter 228

Time flew.

One issue followed another, each bigger than the last, while new truths and suspicions continued surfacing everywhere.

A week passed in the blink of an eye. Then a new article took over the portal sites.

[GojoseonTV] Christie's Auction Held in Secret. Winner: Qatar's Prince Cheonsur. Final Bid: Approximately 500 Billion Won![1226]

The short article included only a single photograph, but its impact was enormous.

Behind the broadly grinning Middle Eastern prince in a turban loomed a gigantic carcass.

> ㄴ **Top Comment:** Isn't that the thing Lord Fuck caught? That Named Monster?
>
> ㄴ Yeah;;; I've seen it so many times I can recognize it just from the hide pattern. But some lunatic actually paid 500 billion[1227] for that thing.
>
> ㄴ The Middle Eastern prince's sheer class blew me away, and Lord Fuck making 500 billion[1228] in one shot made me shit myself.
>
> ㄴ Son, what did you shit? You haven't been looking at anything strange, have you? Mom trusts her son. Love you~

Most people were envious or impressed, but some viewed the news less kindly.

> ㄴ **Top Comment:** Jin Taekyung stirred up all kinds of trouble, refused to give a single interview, then sold the monster behind everyone's backs. Am I the only one bothered by this?
>
> ㄴ Personally, I really don't like him. Killing Won Myunghoon on his own authority was excessive force, if you look at it one way. But the prosecutors' office only questioned him as a witness and then quietly let the matter fade away. It feels like they're giving him special treatment because he's famous.
>
> ㄴ Same. Upvoted.

There was a saying that when your cousin bought land, your stomach hurt.

If even the success of friends and relatives could make someone jealous, then a celebrity they knew only through the media stood no chance.

Not long after the article went up, a bloody battle broke out among the netizens.

[1226] 500 billion won is about $360 million or €320 million.

[1227] 500 billion won is about $360 million or €320 million.

[1228] 500 billion won is about $360 million or €320 million.

> ㄴ **Top Comment:** Are the bastards commenting above the Three Stooges?
>
> ㄴ I'm more shocked that garbage has over a thousand upvotes lol. Why are there so many bastards who can't stand seeing someone else succeed?
>
> ㄴ Exactly. What trouble did he supposedly cause? Did the Dodong Sect[1229] punch a hole through their brains? How many people are alive thanks to Lord Fuck by now?
>
> ㄴ Jin Taekyung… Well, look at this rotten son of a—… As a public figure… what a wicked man, filling only his own pockets… Never forget that the entire nation is watching @~!
>
> ㄴ "Self-interest," lol. The only interest here is the deposits building up in your parents' bodies; what's coming out of my mouth is pure profanity.
>
> ㄴ What are you talking about, public figure? He was a hyung[1230] who was wearing sweatpants and boiling ramen in the corner of his room until a month ago. And that way of talking is disgusting.
>
> ㄴ You young whippersnappers… Such sharp tongues you have~!!!
>
> ㄴ Dentures confiscated for one month.
>
> ㄴ Hearing aid confiscated for two months.
>
> ㄴ Banned from the senior center for three months.

Even as people everywhere had their dentures and hearing aids confiscated and were banned from the senior center, the fighting didn't stop.

Despite the fierce backlash, Jin Taekyung's critics stubbornly continued making their case.

> ㄴ You little brats… hehe. You've put knives on your fingertips… You ignorant, rotten bastards~~!! Ignoring you… is the answer! @!~~
>
> ㄴ Cane confiscated.
>
> ㄴ I don't use a cane… you bastard
>
> ㄴ Wheelchair confiscated.
>
> ㄴ You nameless lowlifes… How dare you come here spouting that commie nonsense…!!!!!
>
> ㄴ Park Hyeongseok. I gave you my name. Happy now?
>
> ㄴ Young Hyeongseok, go back to your mommy, drink some more milk, and study harder`!!
>
> ㄴ You go drink some more.
>
> ㄴ You goddamn lowborn son of a bitch.

[1229] The Dodong Sect is a fabricated martial arts sect Taekyung claimed to belong to.

[1230] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

It was a bloodbath.

In a single day, the article reached one million views and racked up tens of thousands of comments.

As the two sides traded barbed comments and snarled at each other, another article went up.

[HunterTV Exclusive] Jin Taekyung Donates Hundreds of Billions[1231] to Gate Victims and Establishes Support Foundation

Hunter Jin Taekyung has drawn attention by donating hundreds of billions of won[1232] and establishing a support foundation for Gate victims under the name of the Peace Guild.

The necessary procedures had been set in motion even before the Christie's auction began…

> ㄴ **Top Comment:** Everyone who called him a public figure and accused him of lining his own pockets, assemble. Heads to the floor.
>
> ㄴ Tsk, tsk… Nothing has even been properly revealed yet, and you're already running your filthy mouths… Open your eyes to the truth…!
>
> ㄴ LOL. Hey, are you crying?
>
> ㄴ LMAOOOOOO
>
> ㄴ But seriously;;; What the hell is with him giving away hundreds of billions[1233]? Honestly, that's even more amazing than the satisfaction of seeing all those bastards who were maliciously stirring things up get shut down.
>
> ㄴ Agreed. What the hell is Lord Fuck? Is it just easy for someone at his level to make money, so he decided to go big?
>
> ㄴ I don't think that's it. He just doesn't seem greedy for money. Either way, I'm genuinely impressed.
>
> ㄴ Height, looks, character, money. He has everything. Isn't that cheating?
>
> ㄴ P3C, P3C…
>
> ㄴ What does P3C mean?
>
> ㄴ Please have a three-centimeter[1234] dick.
>
> ㄴ Oh.

[1231] "Hundreds of billions" refers to won. Roughly 100–900 billion won is about $71 million–$640 million or €65 million–€580 million.

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[1233] "Hundreds of billions" refers to won. Roughly 100–900 billion won is about $71 million–$640 million or €65 million–€580 million.

[1234] Three centimeters is about 1.2 in.

The battle ended in defeat for the trolls, and public opinion once again filled with admiration for Jin Taekyung.

He had already prevented two major catastrophes and possessed the strength to defeat a Named Monster single-handedly. Now he had shown the generosity to donate hundreds of billions of won[1235] as well.

His image as an unassuming hero and a truly big-hearted man was now firmly cemented.

—Let me update you on the progress of the foundation…

“Team Leader Choi.”

I cut off Team Leader Choi’s voice over the phone in a trembling voice.

“That’s enough. Please don’t say any more.”

—…If it pains you that much to part with the money, should I cancel the foundation?

“No. Absolutely not!”

—Then why are you acting like this?

“It still hurts.”

—Pardon?

“It hurts to give it up, but it needs to be done. Please keep going.”

—Is it like looking at a rice cake in a painting?

“No, it’s a rice cake in my hand. I’m starving to death and barely stopping myself from eating it.”

The secret Christie’s auction attended by wealthy people from around the world had ended not long ago.

Exactly twenty-four hours later, an endless string of zeros appeared in my bank account.

Five hundred billion.[1236]

To be exact, after every fee had been deducted, it came to roughly 530 billion won.[1237]

The unit wasn’t hundreds or thousands. It was *eok*—hundreds of millions.[1238]

It was literally an *eok*-inducing sum, and I nearly cried out myself.

How much money was this, exactly?

[1235] “Hundreds of billions” refers to won. Roughly 100–900 billion won is about $71 million–$640 million or €65 million–€580 million.

[1236] 500 billion won is about $360 million or €320 million.

[1237] 530 billion won is about $380 million or €340 million.

[1238] *Eok* is a Korean number unit meaning one hundred million. In the following sentence, it also evokes a gasp of shock.

It was an astronomical amount—enough to change my life, no, enough to let me and my descendants live in luxury for generations.

But I had already decided where the money should go and how it could be used in the most proper and worthwhile way.

“So please keep going. I’m leaving it all in your hands, Team Leader Choi.”

—Understood. We’ll begin with the people on the list you gave us last time.

“Please take good care of them.”

The families of the teammates whose lives had stopped on that day three years ago would be the foundation’s first recipients.

The money couldn’t fill the empty spaces left by their lost family members, but it could help them pursue their dreams without having to worry about anything.

—Next are the veterans of the Great Cataclysm and single-parent families. Is that correct?

“Yes. Please proceed that way.”

After exchanging a few more words, I ended the call.

When I left the room, I found Mom and Hayeon sitting at the kitchen table eating fruit.

The moment I approached, a fork with a piece of apple speared on it suddenly appeared in front of me.

“Son, have some apple. It’s sweet.”

“Uh, okay.”

Crunch.

The sweet flesh broke apart in my mouth. I quietly ate the fruit while listening to the two of them talk.

Friends, studying, someone who lived nearby, dramas…

Sometimes I laughed quietly. Other times I nodded along.

Then, without warning, I spoke.

“Everyone’s okay, right?”

“Hm? What do you mean, son?”

“What?”

“I mean… with everything that happened. Anything at all.”

Hayeon cocked her head.

“Are you trying to talk about the money?”

“…”

“I knew it. Mom, didn’t I tell you yesterday? I said this guy would definitely be like this.”

Mom smacked Hayeon’s twig-thin forearm.

“You! How can you call your brother, who’s eight years older than you, ‘this guy’?”

"Ow! That hurts. Stop hitting me."

Hayeon grumbled, folded her arms, and leaned back in her chair.

"Excuse me."

"…Excuse me?"

"What would you rather I call you? My family-register roommate?"

She was my one and only little sister, eight years younger than me. Normally, I would have flicked her forehead for the fun of it, but somehow, today wasn't the time.

Hayeon looked at me and let out a deep sigh.

"Oppa."[1239]

"Hm?"

"What does Mom say more than anything else?"

I wondered. What was it?

I didn't have to think long. I heard it whenever I came home—or at least once every few days over the phone.

"Be careful?"

"Right. You know it well."

She poked the apple and held the fork out to me.

"Eat. Eat, and be careful."

"…"

"What good would hundreds of billions[1240] do us? Forget not being able to spend it all. We obviously wouldn't even know how to spend it properly."

I mechanically chewed the apple in my mouth. It was sweet, and it stung like fire—enough to make the tip of my nose tingle.

When did she grow up so much?

This had been a difficult choice for me.

The truth was, I wasn't particularly good or righteous.

I was just an ordinary older brother who wanted to give his only sister everything she asked for, and an ordinary son who wanted his mother, after all the years she had struggled alone, to finally live in comfort.

And hundreds of billions of won[1241] was more than enough to make every fantasy I had ever imagined a reality.

With this much money…

I had agonized over it. Even after making my decision, I kept agonizing.

[1239] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for her older brother or an older man she is close to.

[1240] "Hundreds of billions" refers to won. Roughly 100–900 billion won is about $71 million–$640 million or €65 million–€580 million.

[1241] "Hundreds of billions" refers to won. Roughly 100–900 billion won is about $71 million–$640 million or €65 million–€580 million.

But all of it had been pointless.

People praised me as both a hero and a big-hearted man, but they were wrong.

My sister, eight years younger than me, had a far bigger heart than I did.

She had inherited all of Mom's best qualities. Even her eyes curved into the same crescents when she smiled.

"Son, as I always say…"

"No parent in the world could spend money their child earned by shedding blood. Yes, I know."

"Good. You know it well."

"But you'll have to start spending some now. I plan to earn a lot more."

"Then buy me a massage chair."

"A massage chair?"

"Yeah. I wondered what I'd want first if my son became successful and offered me a present, but that was the only thing I could think of."

I laughed along with Mom.

My heart felt lighter, as though I had finally set down a heavy burden I had carried for a long time.

"Then let's go look at one together tomorrow. We can look at furniture while we're at it."

"Furniture?"

"Come to think of it, the furniture in our house is pretty old, too. Mom, when someone offers you something like this, you're supposed to accept it."

I wondered what expression she would make when she learned that the furniture was for the house we would soon be moving into.

Even more so when she discovered it was the place where the three of us had lived back when we were a family of four.

I'd love to go there right now, but…

I wanted to save that pleasure for tomorrow—or rather, for what came next.

Realizing the time had finally come, I rose from my seat.

"Where are you going?"

"Son, there's still plenty of fruit left."

I smiled broadly at the two disappointed faces and answered,

"It's okay. I think I'll take a nap."

This time, I was going to sleep for a very long time.

Whoooosh.

The winter wind blew, the season already drawing to an end. Darkness had long since swallowed the world outside, while the brightly lit pavilion glowed against the night.

The old man watching the wavering flames suddenly spoke.

“Who’s there?”

A clear voice answered moments later.

“It’s me.”

“…Is that you?”

At first, he hadn’t been able to tell.

In the span of only one or two shichen,[1242] the young man’s footsteps had grown as light as his voice.

Has he gained some kind of insight?

Before, the old man had been able to sense his presence from fifty paces away. This time, he hadn’t noticed him until he came within thirty.

He wasn’t sure whether to call that impressive or bizarre.

Though a smile tugged at the corner of his mouth, his voice was gruff.

“Did I not tell you to come at daybreak?”

“I couldn’t wait. I already know my answer, so why waste time?”

“Tsk, tsk. What kind of martial artist has so little patience?”

“You said it yourself, Old Master. Sleep is a luxury for a martial artist. Spend that time training instead. Am I wrong?”

“Hah! You little rascal.”

He was right. That was how a martial artist should behave—and how a Disciple should treat his master’s words as golden law.

The old man couldn’t hold back any longer and let out a hearty laugh. When he waved his gaunt hand, a gentle blast of heat swept through the pavilion and flung open the door.

Jin Taekyung stood outside, wearing an easy, open smile.

“Old Master. Please teach me martial arts.”

Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, smiled with delight.

“All right. I’ll teach you everything I know.”

[1242] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Chapter 229

"…You're leaving? For an entire year?"

"Yes."

"So you finally decided?"

When I nodded, an indescribably complicated look crossed Jin Wikyung's face. Joy, disappointment, pride…

After a long silence, he bowed deeply to Jeok Cheongang.

"Please take good care of our youngest—no, of Taekyung, Great Hero Jeok."

"I heard you, so get up. He may be lacking, as you said, but this old man will guide him properly. Stop worrying. Ahem!"

"…"

When did he say that? He asked you to take good care of me. I don't remember him saying I was lacking.

But there was no reasoning with Jeok Cheongang.

He composed his twitching lips and spoke again.

"Daylight has broken, so I intend to leave at once."

"What? You mean today?"

"Obviously. Once a man makes up his mind, he must act without hesitation."

Jin Wikyung's expression grew even gloomier. He looked back and forth between Jeok Cheongang and me, his face clouded over, then let out a deep sigh.

"Understood. I'll have your travel bags packed immediately."

"What do we need travel bags for? This is training, not a tour of the martial world."

"Where are you headed?"

"Anhui. It won't take long on foot."

A sudden sense of foreboding made me ask, "How far is it?"

Jin Wikyung answered, "At least a month."

"What?"

"And that's on horseback."

Has this old man gone senile?

Jeok Cheongang saw my expression and barked, "That's only for those slowpokes! At this old man's pace, it won't even take a month and a half!"

"…"

No, damn it. By that logic, a jet would be even faster. So why are we walking?

I quickly grabbed Jin Wikyung's hand.

"Pack my bags nice and full, please."

"You little—!"

"Otherwise, I'm not going."

"What did you say?"

"I'm from a rich family. I have no intention of wandering around begging for food. Since we're going anyway, we might as well travel in comfort."

Why go out of my way to suffer when I had money? If I could travel comfortably, that was all that mattered.

I had already left behind a soft bed and logged in. I didn't want to take things that far.

And besides…

"There are places I need to stop by before we leave."

"Gnnngh."

As Jeok Cheongang groaned, Jin Wikyung added, "I also have something important to discuss with you."

"With me?"

"Yes. It won't take long."

"If you intend to waste my time with some trivial matter, forget it."

Jin Wikyung firmly shook his head.

"It's important enough that you need to know, Great Hero Jeok."

What could it be?

Even I hadn't seen him look this serious in a long time.

Jeok Cheongang studied Jin Wikyung in silence, then clicked his tongue.

"Half a shichen.[1243] No longer."

"That will be enough."

This time, he turned to me.

"The same goes for you."

"Yes, sir."

That was more than enough time for me as well.

Afraid he might change his mind, I answered at once and left the study so the two of them could speak in private.

Clear sunlight and a pleasant breeze greeted me outside. It was hard to call this winter weather anymore.

"Ah, what a beautiful day."

Finding my next destination was easy.

I looked up at the blue sky, then set off toward the distant cliff.

Whoooosh.

[1243] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

An iron sword cleaved through the air with a heavy rush.

Once, then again, every motion flawless down to the last inch.

How long had it been since he had begun each day with ten thousand strikes?

The young man gripping the sword's hilt did not know.

He was inside a cave where no light could enter, and he had long since lost all sense of time.

Swish!

The tip of his sword wavered.

The deviation was minute, but to the young man, it was an unforgivable mistake.

By the rule he had set for himself, every mistake meant another hundred strikes.

Again.

The young man silently swung his sword.

It was a brutal physical regimen that had to be completed with raw strength and stamina alone, without using any internal energy.

An ordinary martial artist would have collapsed from exhaustion long ago.

But this young man, Jin Mukyung, was different.

I'll do it perfectly. No matter how many attempts it takes. No matter how many years.

He had first picked up a sword at the age of five. He loved the whisper of wind against his ears whenever he swung it and the feeling of being drenched in sweat.

More than twenty years passed that way.

At some point, people began calling him by another name.

"Peak at twenty? If that isn't genius, what is?"

"Are you the Heaven Shaking Sword?"

He had trained simply because he loved martial arts and enjoyed becoming stronger. Yet people called him the pride of his family and a martial arts genius.

There had been times when he took pride in the martial name he had earned.

But then he realized it was all hollow fame—an empty name with nothing behind it.

Cheongpung.

Swish!

The instant the name entered his mind, his sword tip twitched.

Another hundred strikes.

He closed his eyes and forced his breathing under control, but his disturbed heart refused to settle.

Before he knew it, Jin Mukyung was remembering the day he had first met Cheongpung.

He's strong.

That was his first thought upon seeing the boy.

Cheongpung had a clear, boyish face and an unremarkable build, with a single iron sword hanging carelessly from his waist. His demeanor and posture could not have looked more careless, yet Mukyung had known at once.

And his intuition had soon proved correct.

It had been the most crushing defeat of his life.

The memory of dropping to his knees after some three hundred exchanges made his teeth clench and his grip tighten around the hilt.

Swish! Swish-swish!

Every ripple in his heart revealed itself through his sword.

His stable stance collapsed, and his movements—once as precise as if measured with a ruler—became disordered.

One hundred extra strikes. Two hundred. Three hundred…

Just as his mistakes began to snowball, a familiar voice came from beyond the iron door sealing the training hall.

“Why does it sound so murderous in there?”

“…!”

Jin Mukyung, who had been swinging his sword as though possessed, froze in place.

“Is that you?”

“Why ask when you already know? You’ll hurt my feelings.”

There was no mistaking him.

Only one person in the Taiyuan Jin Family could speak to Jin Mukyung with such insolence.

Thinking of his younger brother beyond the iron door, Mukyung asked, “How long have you been there?”

“About fifteen minutes?”

“…I see.”

Despite the casual answer, Mukyung’s face darkened.

He had allowed himself to be swept up in his emotions and failed to notice Taekyung’s presence.

“Go away. I’m training.”

“Training, my ass. More like taking out your anger.”

“What?”

“I can hear how furious you are. Whatever you do in that state, it won’t be training.”

Jin Mukyung’s eyes trembled faintly.

He was astonished that Taekyung had seen straight through his condition despite

the iron door between them and the distance of more than ten jang.[1244]

This guy… Has he improved again already?

His rate of growth was truly terrifying.

Before Mukyung's surprise could fade, Jin Taekyung continued.

"I'm leaving."

"You're leaving?"

"Yeah. I decided to learn martial arts from the Fire King—or rather, the Old Master."

"…!"

Mukyung had heard that the Fire King had come to visit the family.

In the past, he would have rushed out of the training hall at once, bowed until his forehead struck the ground, and begged the Fire King to teach him even a single move.

But he had restrained himself.

More than anyone, he knew that this was a process he had to understand for himself.

But why would he teach that boy…? No. There are more than enough reasons.

The man beyond that iron door was the true monster, the one who deserved to be called a genius. The Fire King could hardly have failed to recognize his worth.

Once Mukyung had accepted that, he asked, "Have you become his Disciple?"

"Not exactly. I'm sort of a Disciple, but not a Disciple, while also being kind of a Disciple. Something like that."

"…What the fuck are you talking about?"

"Don't bother trying to understand. Is this the first time something like this has happened?"

"That's true."

"Yeah. Just let it go."

A brief silence followed.

Then, as if by agreement, they both chuckled.

Even they had to admit the conversation had taken an absurd turn.

"Did you come here just to tell me that? Were you hoping for a send-off?"

"A send-off? I know better than to expect one."

"Then what?"

"One year left."

Taekyung's calm voice continued.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet.

[1244] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

The Star-Array Grand Banquet.

Jin Mukyung repeated the words like a groan.

A banquet hall for the countless stars adorning the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes,[1245] the Four Seas and Five Lakes.[1246]

That was the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

“Why are you telling me?”

“I’m going to attend. Cheongpung and I both are.”

“…What are you trying to say?”

“That’s for you to think about on your own. Oof.”

There came the sound of Taekyung rising, followed by his final words.

“I’m off. See you later.”

Step. Step.

His footsteps gradually receded, then vanished altogether.

Silence settled over the training hall.

Jin Mukyung stared blankly at the iron door beyond which the other’s presence had vanished.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet.

He was no fool.

He knew exactly why Jin Taekyung had come to the training hall and why he had brought up the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

“One year…”

Jin Mukyung murmured under his breath and tightened his grip on the sword.

Before he knew it, his turbulent heart had calmed, and the wavering tip of his sword had stilled.

“Safe travels. I’ll see you then.”

Murmuring the farewell he had failed to give his younger brother before his long journey, Jin Mukyung swung his sword like lightning.

Whoooosh.

A perfect strike, without the slightest deviation.

After leaving the training hall, I headed straight for the study.

What awaited me there was an empty chair and a message from one of the guards.

“He told me to wait at the main gate?”

“Yes. Those were his exact words.”

[1245] The Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes is a literary expression for the whole world, from its inhabited regions to its distant reaches.

[1246] The Four Seas and Five Lakes is a traditional expression for the lands and waterways of the world.

Did something happen?

Setting the question aside, I made my way to the main gate. Before long, I found several familiar faces waiting for me.

“Captain!”

“Benefactor!”

“You’re finally here, Young Master Jin?”

Hyuk Mujin, Cheongpung, and Wolhwa.

And they weren’t alone.

Over the shoulders of the three who had approached me first, I could see the others as well.

Lee Seowol, awkwardly waving one hand, and the Three Plum Blossom Elites, standing there with expressions that seemed to say they had no idea where they were or who they were.

“How did you all know to come?”

Wolhwa smiled sweetly.

“Because we’re the Lower District Sect.”

“…Did you plant a spy?”

“Oh my, a spy? Why would we need one when we have such an excellent informant right there?”

I followed her pointing finger and found Hyuk Mujin proudly holding out a heavy travel bag.

“The Lesser Family Head ordered me to pack your luggage, Captain!”

“…Oh. So you’re the culprit.”

“Pardon?”

“Nothing. Good job.”

I had hoped to leave as quietly as possible, but nothing ever went according to plan.

The moment I accepted the travel bag with a sigh, Cheongpung grabbed me by the collar and clung to me.

“Benefactor! I want to go with you! I want to become Grandpa Jeok’s Disciple!”

“Then go get permission.”

“From whom?”

“Who do you think? Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint.”

“I already did! He said I could go!”

Baek Museong muttered with the face of a man who had grown weary of life.

“He’s been missing for over a month. How in the world did you get his permission…?”

That man really is living life on the hardest difficulty.

After finally prying Cheongpung off me, I asked Baek Museong, “What are you planning to do now?”

“Either escort Martial Uncle Cheongpung back to the main sect or search the entire Central Plains for Grandmaster’s trail. I suppose it will be one or the other.”

“Yikes.”

Baek Museong burst into hearty laughter at my reaction.

“Haha! What in life is ever easy? I intend to leave as soon as a message arrives from the main sect.”

Now that’s mental fortitude.

I even felt a little respect for him.

After finishing my conversation with Baek Museong, I turned my head.

Beside the petite Eunhyang, a giant nearly two meters[1247] tall flinched.

“Hey.”

“…Wh-what?”

“I’m just saying we should forget what happened and try to get along.”

I smiled brightly and held out my hand.

The giant—Chulwoo of the Defeated Flower Fist—hesitated before taking it.

“Th-then this means we’ve made up…”

Crack.

“Gah!”

“What a baby. Don’t let it show. Smile.”

With the sound of bones shifting out of place, Chulwoo’s hand—despite the man being twice my size—crumpled as if caught in a hydraulic press.

I tightened my grip and whispered in his ear.

“Don’t hit on her. You know what I mean, right?”

“I-I understand!”

“Good. Keep it that way for the rest of your life.”

When I released his hand, Chulwoo sucked in a breath and hurriedly backed away.

Watching him, Eunhyang, the youngest of the Three Plum Blossom Elites, could only marvel.

“…I never knew there was someone stronger than Senior Brother Chul. The world truly is vast.”

Then again, it could be small, too.

No matter how enormous this continent was, the people destined to meet would find each other eventually.

I would probably see them again someday.

“If fate brings us together again, I’ll see you then.”

[1247] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

"It was nice meeting you, too."

I gave Eunhyang a slight nod and turned away.

One person remained.

"…"

"…"

An awkward silence hung between Lee Seowol and me.

I didn't think things had been this awkward at first. I had no idea why Lee Seowol seemed harder to face every time I saw her.

Is it because of the proposal?

Even if it was for a political marriage, a proposal was still a proposal.

After squirming in discomfort, I finally managed to speak.

"Um, Sect Leader Lee."

"Please call me Young Lady."

"Ah, yes. Then, Young Lady Lee."

"Yes. Go ahead."

I looked at Lee Seowol's slightly lowered eyelids and brought out the words I had prepared.

"May peace prevail throughout your household."

"…"

"May your business prosper, too, and, well… Anyway, I hope everything you do goes well."

Great. Nailed it. What better blessing could there be for the leader of an entire sect?

I smiled in satisfaction and was about to study Lee Seowol's reaction when a sharp voice rang out from the distance.

"What are you grinning like a fool for?"

A short old man appeared in the distance.

With Jin Wikyung and Wipeng flanking him, he seized me by the nape before I had a chance to say anything.

"We have a long road ahead. Hurry up and follow me."

"W-wait a second."

Whoooosh!

But it was already too late.

Everyone's faces rapidly receded into the distance.

Jin Wikyung waved a handkerchief, his eyes red, and shouted, "My youngest! Come back safe and sound!"

…That only makes me more nervous!

Chapter 230

Luoyang, the thousand-year-old capital.

This historic city, whose legacy stretched back thousands of years, was one of the foremost centers of commerce, literature, and art under heaven.

Even in vast Henan Province, Luoyang was unrivaled in size. Wherever one went in the city, crowds filled the streets.

The same was true of a small inn on Luoyang's outskirts.

"Two bowls of huimian noodles![1248]"

"Yes, yes! Coming right up!"

"Three more bottles of baijiu![1249]"

"Right away!"

Merchants who had just completed a long journey clinked cups in broad daylight. A group of scholars held a heated debate nearby, alongside shabby singers who looked down on their luck.

And of course, there was one group found wherever people gathered.

Martial artists.

Crash!

The inn's door exploded into splinters, and five or six swordsmen poured inside.

The one-eyed man leading them shouted without hesitation.

"Get them!"

His shout was directed toward a secluded corner of the inn.

A group of fierce-looking men had been guzzling strong liquor straight from a large jar. They overturned their table and leaped to their feet.

"Damn it, the Dongcheon Sect?"

"Kill them!"

Clang! Clang-clang!

With a deafening cacophony, more than a dozen martial artists drew their weapons and clashed.

Blades tangled and sprang apart, throwing sparks into the air. Tables split, and everything on them went flying in all directions.

"R-run!"

"It's the Dongcheon Sect! The dark-path men are fighting!"

The Murim was not made up solely of righteous heroes.

[1248] Huimian is a Henan noodle dish made with broad, hand-pulled noodles served in broth.

[1249] Baijiu is a strong Chinese distilled liquor.

The orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction, and dark-path figures coexisted, while thousands of li away[1250] stood the Demonic Cult, said to be filled with fiends and monsters.

Among them, the Dongcheon Sect was a dark-path faction that ruled Luoyang's nights.

"…I'm ruined!"

The innkeeper, who had been cheerfully taking orders moments ago, collapsed onto the floor.

The Dongcheon Sect was no common gang of ruffians. Despite being a dark-path faction, it had more than fifty years of deeply rooted history and strong connections within the government.

If he dared report this incident, they would beat him to a pulp.

Please, just don't let anyone die.

The innkeeper's desperate wish crumbled the very next moment.

Slash!

"Grrrk."

With a chilling sound, one of the men clutched his throat and fell.

He was one of the dark-path swordsmen who had recently gotten into a minor dispute with the Dongcheon Sect.

"Gungsu!"

"You goddamn bastards!"

Driven mad by their comrade's death, the swordsmen charged at the enemy, swinging their weapons.

But in a fight between evenly matched dark-path swordsmen, nothing mattered more than numbers.

"One of them's down!"

"Finish off the rest!"

The Dongcheon Sect's swordsmen were experienced and ruthless. They exploited every opening, stabbing and slashing without mercy. Blood sprayed each time their blades flashed.

Swish-swish-swish! Thud!

"Gaaaaah!"

"Guh!"

"P-please, spare me!"

The one-eyed man burst into laughter at the last survivor's plea. He was a lower-ranking officer of the Dongcheon Sect.

"What? Spare you?"

[1250] This uses the Chinese *li*, a unit of distance equal to about 500 m (0.311 mi).

“Please, just this once. If you let me go, I’ll never—”

“You should’ve known who you were dealing with.”

Thunk!

A dagger shot from his sleeve and buried itself in the last swordsman’s forehead.

“Gueugh.”

Thump!

With a grotesque groan, the corpse toppled backward like a rotten old tree.

“You’ve got no pride at all. And you call yourself a dark-path man.”

The one-eyed man retrieved the dagger from the corpse’s forehead and crooked a finger at his underlings.

“Clean this up.”

“Yes, sir!”

With a vigorous reply, the swordsmen gathered the bodies and piled them together. The once-peaceful inn had long since become a sea of blood.

Step. Step. Tap.

The one-eyed man blocked the wrecked entrance and swept his gaze over the terrified innkeeper and guests.

“Some of you know who I am, and some of you don’t. So I’ll trouble myself to tell you again.”

In the suffocating silence, everyone froze beneath the cold, murderous gleam in his eyes.

His harsh voice sounded as though he had swallowed iron filings.

“I am Heukgeol, the lone beast of the mighty Dongcheon Gang—”

Smack! Boom!

Everyone inside the inn blinked, stunned by what had happened so suddenly.

Heukgeol, the lone beast of the Dongcheon Gang who had been blocking the entrance like Mount Tai,[1251] was nowhere to be seen. In his place stood a short old man.

“You son of a bitch. Why are you blocking the entrance?”

“…”

An unseen tremor swept through the inn.

Only then did the guests notice Heukgeol embedded in one of the walls. Their eyes widened.

Gasp!

A martial artist!

He’s a master. An incredibly powerful one!

[1251] Mount Tai is a mountain in China traditionally associated with great size and weight.

While everyone was still reeling in shock, a young man who had entered behind the old man spoke with an incredulous expression.

“Still, was it really necessary to beat him like that? What if he dies?”

“Who cares whether some dark-path piece of garbage lives or dies?”

The old man answered gruffly and jerked his chin toward the inn, which had become a sea of blood.

More precisely, he pointed at the Dongcheon Sect’s swordsmen, who were gathering the corpses and severed limbs.

They stared at the old man with vacant expressions.

“Look. Can’t you see? That’s the kind of people they are. There’s nothing in their heads, so whenever they meet, all they can do is swing swords at each other.”

“Wow. They really deserve to die.”

“Right?”

“Yes. Shall we eat now?”

“Order the drinks first. I’ve inhaled so much dust that my throat’s scratchy.”

“Got it.”

The young man answered brightly and hurried over to the innkeeper.

“You have rooms, right?”

“Y-yes?”

The innkeeper, only half-conscious, answered automatically.

“Of course, sir.”

“Then give us the best room you have, and three bottles of baijiu.[1252] As for the food…”

The old man, who had already claimed a table, shouted from behind the young man.

“Crisp-roasted duck and huimian![1253] You have to eat huimian[1254] when you come to Luoyang.”

“Sir, you heard him, right?”

“Yes, sir.”

“How much will that be altogether?”

Such was the power of habit.

The innkeeper instinctively calculated the entire bill and was just about to name the price when—

“You crazy bastard!”

“Fuck! Get him!”

They were not called dark-path figures for nothing.

[1252] Baijiu is a strong Chinese distilled liquor.

[1253] Huimian is a Henan noodle dish made with broad, hand-pulled noodles served in broth.

[1254] Huimian is a Henan noodle dish made with broad, hand-pulled noodles served in broth.

They lived mayfly lives, born in the back alleys and destined to die in them.

Armed with their innate simplicity and ferocity, the Dongcheon Sect's low-ranking swordsmen rolled their eyes back and charged at the young man.

"Die!"

The bald man at the front let out a thunderous shout and swung a crude, broad-bladed saber.

The blade, red with rust, came down toward the crown of the young man's head.

Or rather, it was about to.

Whoosh! Crunch!

With a chilling sound, the bald man crumpled. His jaw had been shattered, and he was already unconscious.

The saber slipped from his limp hand.

Clunk. Clatter.

"I thought hair was the only thing you were missing. Turns out you've got no skill either."

The young man muttered without much interest and turned back to the innkeeper.

"So, how much was it?"

"…"

"…"

The atmosphere inside the inn, already frozen solid, somehow froze even harder.

As countless people watched with bulging eyes, the young man paid the bill and even collected his change.

He was walking toward the old man's table when he suddenly stopped.

"Hey."

The Dongcheon Sect's swordsmen, frozen like statues beneath his gaze, flinched.

"Yes, sir?"

"Were you talking to us?"

The young man nodded.

"Yeah. What are you going to do?"

"W-what do you mean?"

"That thing in your hand. If you're going to swing it, hurry up and swing. Otherwise, put it away. It's ugly."

Shk-shk-shk!

The swordsmen sheathed their weapons with lightning speed.

"Now collect the bodies and your friends. Move."

"Yes, sir! Moving!"

"Clean up the mess you made while you're at it."

Repeating the order like men desperate to stay alive, the swordsmen moved in perfect unison.

They gathered up the corpses and the bald man, then pulled the one-eyed man out of the wall. Afterward, they swallowed nervously and waited for their next order.

“Why are you standing there gawking? Get the hell out.”

“Th-thank you!”

That was precisely what they had been praying to hear.

Afraid they might be stopped, they hurried out of the inn. The young man’s next words shot after them like an arrow.

“If I see your faces one more time, you’re dead. Remember that.”

“Yes, sir!”

“Yeah, take care.”

A suffocating silence filled the inn.

As the young man walked toward the old man’s table beneath everyone’s horrified gazes, he suddenly drew a sharp breath.

Gasp!

Had the Dongcheon Sect attacked again?

The people who had been watching his every move jumped and looked around.

But the young man’s gaze was fixed on only one thing: the roast duck that had appeared on the table.

“H-how could you?”

His eyes bulged, his pupils trembling as though an earthquake had struck.

After a brief silence, the young man shouted,

“How could you eat both legs by yourself?!”

“…”

Seven days and nights.

That was how long it had taken us to get from Taiyuan to Luoyang.

Even riding at full speed, the journey would normally have taken ten days. There was no point explaining what it had been like to cover that distance in only seven.

The important thing was that I hadn’t complained even once.

But still…

“This isn’t right!”

I was genuinely furious.

He had eaten both legs! And this was my first proper meal in an entire week!

He had even left me with only one wing.

“Even dark-path bastards don’t do this!”

I kept shoving whatever food I could grab into my mouth as I vented my outrage. Across from me, Jeok Cheongang looked utterly dumbfounded.

"Look at this ill-mannered brat. You dare shout at this old man over something so trivial? What was that? Dark-path bastards?"

"Am I wrong? Even the Demonic Cult Leader would eat only one duck leg."

"You little—"

Whoosh!

A gentle heat began to rise from Jeok Cheongang's palm when a gruff voice suddenly cut in.

"Hey, let me ask you something."

A hulking man entered the inn with heavy footsteps. His face was covered in scars.

Behind him came dozens of dark-path swordsmen with equally menacing faces.

His face alone is rated 18+.

The one-eyed man Jeok Cheongang had dealt with earlier had looked vicious enough, but compared to this giant, he could have passed for a model prisoner.

Is looking the part half the job around here?

Well, at least it made them easy to identify.

Jeok Cheongang didn't even bother looking at them, so I answered in his place.

"Yeah, that's us."

"I heard some very interesting news, but…"

Confusion flickered across the giant's face.

"What?"

"I haven't even asked yet."

"It's obvious. The interesting news you heard was that some old man and a fresh-faced young guy showed up and beat a bunch of your lackeys half to death. Something like that, right?"

"…"

"Yeah, I know. Come on in. And bring all the friends you brought along just in case. You can attack together."

This outcome had been entirely predictable.

Maybe the men I'd let go had called them, or maybe someone among the onlookers had informed their gang. It didn't really matter.

I can just beat them down as they come.

The difference in strength was overwhelming.

Against men at this level, the result would be the same whether ten or a hundred of them came rushing in. There was no need to kill them. I could brush them aside like flies.

"Not coming? Then I'll come to you."

“You little bastard!”

Still, the man who had come this time had some instincts.

Perhaps sensing something ominous, the giant edged backward and waved his hand.

“Get him!”

Schliing.

Dozens of weapons had just begun to emerge from their sheaths when—

“Amitabha.[1255] C-could we pass through for a moment?”

[1255] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

Chapter 231

"Amitabha.[1256] E-excuse me, but may I pass through for a moment?"

The timid voice belonged to a young monk in shabby robes.

Clutching a large strand of prayer beads in one hand, he bowed repeatedly as he squeezed between the dark-path swordsmen.

"Pardon me, then. Amitabha, Amitabha…"

"Hey. Look at this guy."

"Huh?"

The swordsmen stared in bewilderment at the monk who had appeared out of nowhere and begun fearlessly pushing through their ranks.

Several of them quickly came to their senses and tried to block him, only to be shoved helplessly aside.

"W-what the hell?"

"Damn. How is he so strong…?"

Skrrt! Thump!

No matter who challenged him, the result was the same. No one could stop him.

That was when I realized just how much muscle was hidden beneath the monk's old, baggy robes.

Thick forearms. Bulging veins. At first glance, he seemed to have an average build, but underneath those robes, he was packed with dense, combat-ready muscle.

Damn, look at those muscles. That's insane.

At that point, he looked like he should be wearing Under Armour instead of a monk's robe.

While I marveled in silence, the monk finally made it through the dozens of dark-path swordsmen and wiped the sweat from his brow.

His face was taut with nerves.

"Phew…"

The hulking man wasn't about to let that pass. His face had turned bright red, and his eyebrows kept twitching.

As he looked back and forth between the monk and me, apparently unsure which one of us to deal with first, I waved at him.

"Hey, take your time. I'll wait."

"…How considerate of you."

Grind.

Gritting his teeth at me, the hulking man stepped in front of the monk.

"Who are you supposed to be?"

[1256] *Amitabha* is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

“This poor monk is…”

“Never mind.”

His sharp gaze swept over the monk from head to toe.

“You’re a monk?”

“Of course.”

“You don’t even have a precept seal on your forehead.”

A drop of sweat ran down the monk’s brow.

“My training has not yet progressed far enough for me to receive them.”

“Training, huh? What’s your Dharma name?”

“I have yet to receive one of those as well.”

“So you’re a monk with neither precept seals nor a Dharma name…”

The hulking man muttered under his breath, then let out a short laugh and turned to his subordinates.

“Just going by the packaging, he looks exactly like one of us. Don’t you think?”

“Yes, sir!”

“He looks like he’d be good at the job. We should take him in as our youngest.”

“Right?”

The hulking man roared with laughter, then abruptly went stone-faced and glared at the monk.

“Where did you come from?”

“…I’m afraid I don’t understand.”

“I know all about you, you bastard. I asked where you came from. The Poison Dragon Sect? Or the Black Blood Sect?”

“T-the Poison Dragon Sect? The Black Blood Sect? This poor monk comes from Shaolin.”

“What? Shaolin? Shaolin Temple on Mount Song?”

“Yes.”

Shaolin Temple?

Now this was getting interesting.

Even Jeok Cheongang, who had been ignoring everything happening behind him, turned to watch.

“Old Master, he says he’s from Shaolin Temple.”

“Be quiet. I’m deciding how to deal with an ill-mannered brat like you.”

“…”

That wasn’t good news.

My expression probably looked a lot like the monk’s right about now.

His face had fallen as he stared at the hulking man, who burst into thunderous laughter.

“Ha-ha-ha-ha! Shaolin Temple? You’re claiming to be from Shaolin Temple?”

“B-benefactor, why are you laughing?”

“Benefactor, my ass. Who the fuck is this mangy stray, crawling out of nowhere and spouting bullshit to my face?”

Boom!

The hulking man’s fist shattered the solid wall.

Unlike his subordinates, who were Second or Third Rate at best, he possessed enough martial prowess to pass himself off as a Peak master wherever he went.

Though he had only barely entered the realm.

“You little bastard… You think our Dongcheon Sect is a joke? Do I look that stupid to you?”

“Benefactor, you seem agitated. Please calm yourself. Settle your heart.”

“Settle my ass!”

Boom!

What remained of the wall crumbled to the floor.

The innkeeper watching from the back probably felt his heart crumble along with it.

“You don’t have the precept seals that should be carved into your forehead, you don’t have a Dharma name, and you look like the perfect dark-path thug, but you expect me to believe you’re a monk? You little shit. Why don’t you just tell me the Abbot of Shaolin is your master?”

“Gasp! How did you know?”

The young monk’s eyes widened.

That was the last straw for the hulking man.

“You son of a—!”

Whoosh!

A mace covered in sharp steel spikes hurtled toward the monk. It traced a clean, practiced arc worthy of an experienced First Rate master.

With a startled gasp, the monk raised the prayer beads in his hand.

Screams erupted from the crowd watching outside the inn.

“Eek!”

“Look out!”

But what they feared never happened.

Clang!

With a sharp metallic ring, something came raining down.

Astonishingly, the small, pointed objects raining down were the steel spikes that had covered the mace.

“…Huh?”

The hulking man stared at his mace in confusion.
Then the young monk shouted in a terrified voice,
“Benefactor, you started this!”
“W-wait!”
But the situation had already taken an unexpected turn.
Rattle-rattle-rattle!
The absurdly large prayer beads wrapped around the monk’s entire arm.
The beads threaded between his fingers gleamed with a strangely familiar sheen.
Wait. Could those be…
Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?
The realization flashed through my mind just as a horrifying sound rang out.
Crack! Crunch!
A single punch shattered the mace and drove straight into the hulking man’s side.
“Guh!”
His mouth fell open from the pain, and blood poured from between his lips.
“W-wait!”
The hulking man cried out desperately, but his plea never reached his opponent.
Already white as a sheet, the young monk squeezed his eyes shut and shouted,
“Amitabha!”
Thud!
“Namu!”[1257]
Crack!
“Avalokiteshvara!”[1258]
Crunch!
“Amitabha, Amitabha, Amitabhaaa!”
Bam-bam-bam-bam-bam!
He hit him, broke him, then struck the places he had already hit again.
Every time the gleaming prayer beads shot forward, blood sprayed through the air.
Watching the scene, I muttered like I was groaning in pain.
“Oh, shit…”
That was the strongest reaction I could muster.
I had expected the monk to win from the moment he appeared, but I had never imagined he would be this insane.
“T-that…”
Jeok Cheongang had shot to his feet at some point. His mouth hung open.

[1257] *Namu* means “homage to” and begins a Buddhist invocation.
[1258] *Avalokiteshvara* is a bodhisattva associated with compassion.

“The Arhat Fist!”[1259]

“Arhat? As in Shaolin’s Hundred and Eight Arhats?”

“Y-yes. That is definitely Shaolin martial arts.”

“…That is?”

I looked back.

The young monk’s eyes had half rolled back in his head as he delivered the finishing blow to the fallen man.

“Gate, gate, paragateeek!”[1260]

Bam-bam-bam!

The scene was covered in brutal violence and blood. I wiped the blood from my cheek and barely managed to speak.

“…Old Master.”

“Speak.”

“Is that really Shaolin martial arts?”

“…Technically.”

“Then why can’t I feel even a trace of the Buddha’s compassion or anything like that?”

After a brief pause, Jeok Cheongang gave a short answer.

“At least he didn’t kill him.”

“…”

At this point, killing him seemed like it might actually be kinder.

But I swallowed the words before they could escape.

Clink, clink.

The prayer beads swung and rattled with every step.

A blood-drenched robe and a pair of unsteady eyes drew closer.

“Um, excuse me.”

“Yes?”

“Forgive me, but may I ask your name, Benefactor?”

“W-why?”

My voice trembled despite myself.

The young murderer—no, the young monk—edged closer with timid steps.

“Could you perhaps be a member of the Jin family…?”

“I’m sorry. You have me confused with someone else.”

“That is Jin Taekyung.”

When Jeok Cheongang cut in, I immediately changed my answer.

[1259] An *arhat* is a person who has attained enlightenment in Buddhism. The Hundred and Eight Arhats are associated with Shaolin martial tradition.

[1260] “Gate, gate, paragate” is part of the Buddhist Heart Sutra’s closing mantra, commonly rendered “gone, gone, gone beyond.”

"That's right. I was only joking. I didn't offend you, did I?"

"Amitabha. Of course not."

Fortunately, he didn't seem upset.

Unlike me, who kept glancing uneasily at the prayer beads, he wore a joyful smile around his mouth.

If not for the drop of blood splattered beneath his chin, I might have thought, *So this is what the smile of a Buddha looks like.*

"But why were you looking for me?"

"This poor monk was ordered to bring the Master of Morning Star."

The master of what?

Before I could ask again, Jeok Cheongang abruptly spoke.

"Do you know Hong Dao?"

"Yes. He is my master."

"…Hah. That damned monk is as uncanny as ever. He can still see a thousand li[1261] without leaving his seat."

"Then you must be the Fire King, Great Hero Jeok Cheongang."

"Did your master tell you that too?"

The young monk silently bowed his head, and Jeok Cheongang let out a short laugh.

"No need for a lengthy explanation, then. Take us to Hong Dao."

"Yes."

As Yama[1262] disguised as a monk led the way, the crowd parted like the Red Sea.

Taking advantage of the renewed commotion, I asked Jeok Cheongang in a low voice,

"Old Master, who is Hong Dao?"

"The Abbot of Shaolin."

That alone was surprising, but Jeok Cheongang wasn't finished.

"In the Murim, they call him the Dharma King."

"…"

Unnamed.

That was the Dharma name of the young monk who introduced himself as the Disciple of Dharma King Hong Dao.

Though, technically, it could hardly be called a Dharma name.

[1261] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 meters (0.311 miles); a thousand li is about 500 kilometers (310 miles).

[1262] *Yama* is a Buddhist lord of the underworld.

It literally meant he had no name.

“He hasn’t changed a bit, even in his old age. What kind of Dharma name is that to give a Disciple?”

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue, and Unnamed smiled sheepishly.

“My master gave it to me, so it is both my name and my Dharma name.”

“From what this old man can tell, you don’t seem to have been formally accepted as his Disciple. Do you have no regrets about that?”

“Is it not all Heaven’s will?”

Unnamed pointed toward the sky with a bright smile.

Jeok Cheongang shook his head.

“Even when choosing a Disciple, he really… How should I put this?”

After a moment’s hesitation, he continued,

“He chose an unusual one.”

“Hehe. Amitabha. Thank you.”

“…”

“…”

Don’t laugh. That wasn’t a compliment. And stop saying Amitabha.

Even now, whenever I closed my eyes, I could vividly see Unnamed drenched in blood.

When he smiled, he looked like a living Buddha. But the moment he slipped those prayer beads between his fingers, everything within ten meters[1263] turned into a living hell.

This bastard is the scariest one here.

From what I had heard during the half day we’d traveled together, he was so naturally introverted that once he snapped, he couldn’t control himself.

Jeok Cheongang tilted his head a few times before giving a vague nod, but I had a different opinion.

I even knew his exact diagnosis.

Anger-management disorder.

The man was a walking time bomb.

That was why I had been trying to stay behind Unnamed whenever possible.

A Peak master with anger-management disorder could strangle me with those Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron prayer beads.

Getting strangled with prayer beads… No. Absolutely not.

Fortunately, the journey from Luoyang to Mount Song didn’t take long.

The two were close to each other, and the roads were well maintained thanks to the many pilgrims who visited Shaolin Temple.

[1263] Ten meters is about 33 feet.

As we reached the foot of Mount Song, wooden buildings began to appear in the distance.

“Are we there?”

Jeok Cheongang shook his head.

“Not yet. We still have to climb halfway up Shaoshi Peak. Visitors without a specific purpose are only permitted to stay at the Guest Reception Hall.”

“You know this place well. Have you been here often?”

“I’ve stopped by often.”

“Oh.”

Well, the Abbot of Shaolin was his friend. I supposed it was only natural for him to know that much.

Jeok Cheongang dismounted and began climbing Shaoshi Peak. After a while, he abruptly spoke.

“You haven’t given up that lazy habit, I see. Do you still sleep five shichen[1264] a day?”

The next moment, an unexpected answer came from a broad, flat rock far above us.

It was a presence only a master of Jeok Cheongang’s caliber could have sensed.

“Hmm. Five shichen[1265]. There was a time when I could sleep that long.”

The voice resembled the tolling of a bell in an ancient temple.

It was quiet yet weighty, with a deep resonance.

“Being the Abbot of Shaolin is a grave responsibility. I can no longer sleep as much as I used to.”

“Is that so?”

“Of course. It is a sense of responsibility that a carefree Fire Gate Sect Leader like you could never understand.”

Jeok Cheongang and Hong Dao spoke as casually as if they had seen each other only yesterday.

“So how many shichen[1266] do you sleep?”

“Hmm. Well, you see…”

Whoosh.

A black silhouette slowly descended from the broad, flat rock several dozen meters[1267] above us.

Very slowly, stepping on empty air as though it were solid ground, Dharma King Hong Dao landed and smiled like a child.

[1264] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.
[1265] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.
[1266] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.
[1267] Several dozen meters is roughly 100–200 feet.

"Only about four shichen[1268]."

"You lazy bastard."

A smile tugged at the corners of Fire King Jeok Cheongang's mouth.

[1268] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

Chapter 232

Unlike the short Jeok Cheongang, Dharma King Hong Dao was a remarkably tall old man.

His eyes sparkled with mischief, and his steps were full of vigor as he climbed the mountain path.

Where are we going, anyway?

It was only natural to wonder. He had abandoned the well-maintained road and was deliberately taking paths hardly anyone ever used.

After walking for some time, Hong Dao finally stopped.

“Humble guests have come to this precious place. I know it may be a burden, but don’t stand on ceremony. Come in.”

Jeok Cheongang stared at the so-called precious place before speaking.

“Did you get kicked out of Shaolin Temple or something?”

“Hm? Why?”

“You really have to ask? What happened to your residence?”

Just as Jeok Cheongang had said, the place was surrounded by thick weeds and trees. It looked far too shabby to be the residence of the Abbot of Shaolin Temple, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim.[1269]

“Be honest. You got fired as Abbot of Shaolin, didn’t you?”

Seriously, what was he, a convenience-store part-timer?

Dumbfounded by Jeok Cheongang’s words, I asked, “Can an Abbot even be fired?”

“What a narrow-minded fool. Rebels can depose an emperor, so why couldn’t they do the same to an Abbot of Shaolin?”

“…”

When he put it that way, I had nothing to say.

Besides, I used to beat monsters for a living in the modern world. In a world with Demon Kings and Gates, I supposed even the Abbot of Shaolin could be a temporary employee.

Hong Dao, who had been listening to our exchange, chuckled.

“Wherever I am becomes the Abbot’s quarters. We don’t bother with such formalities at Shaolin. Isn’t that right, Disciple?”

Unnamed answered, “He is currently staying here despite the Discipline Hall’s pleas for him to return.”

“…”

Like friend, like friend. This old man was no pushover either.

[1269] “Mount Tai and Northern Dipper” is a traditional honorific for a preeminent authority; Mount Tai is a mountain in China, and the Northern Dipper is a group of stars.

Hong Dao, however, only laughed heartily as he pulled out some kind of staff from inside his robes and waved it around.

"What can they do? They're the ones who forced the position of Abbot on someone who said he didn't want it."

It was a ridiculously short staff. Its surface, polished by countless hands, gleamed as though it had been oiled, and a faint green light shimmered across it.

And there's some strange-looking stone set into it.

Its shape somewhat resembled the staffs used by mages.

But there was something different about Hong Dao's green staff. Beyond the marks left by time, it possessed a unique energy all its own.

What is that?

My question was answered the next moment.

"The Green Jade Buddha Staff. To think they entrusted a thousand-year-old sacred treasure of Shaolin, one bearing such immense authority, to a dirty monk like this. They must all be blind."

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue.

"Shaolin is really going downhill."

"It's still doing much better than the Fire Gate Clan, which has all of one Disciple."

"What did you say?"

"Your fiery temper hasn't changed. I hope you're reborn as a good and calm person in your next life."

"My next life? Why are you killing me off when I'm still perfectly healthy?"

"Oh, my. A corpse is talking. Amitabha.[1270]"

"Hong Dao, you dirty monk!"

I watched the two of them bicker as they entered the Buddha hall, then turned around.

Unnamed was looking at me with a faint smile.

"They both seem pleased to see an old friend after so long."

"…I can't imagine how they ever became friends."

The eccentric Abbot of Shaolin and the foul-tempered Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan.

Their personalities might be a decent match, but they still didn't seem like the sort of pair who would become friends. Besides, hadn't Jeok Cheongang killed countless people, despite Buddhism's prohibition against taking life?

Unnamed thought over my dubious remark, then suddenly smacked his gleaming forehead.

"Ah, I remember now."

[1270] *Amitabha* is an invocation of the Buddha of Infinite Light.

“You startled me. I thought you were about to use Solar Fist… But what did you remember?”

“How they became friends. During the Great Faction War, my master was secretly drinking and eating meat. Benefactor Jeok caught him, and they became drinking buddies afterward.”

“What?”

For a moment, I wondered if I had misheard him.

“He was drinking and eating meat?”

“Yes.”

“Wasn’t he already the Abbot of Shaolin back then?”

“That is correct.”

“Oh, so the monks here eat meat. Well, I suppose they need to bulk up while training in martial arts, so that makes sense…”

“That is not the case. Buddhism forbids taking life. Livestock are no exception.”

“…?”

“…?”

Where had this conversation gone wrong?

I stared blankly at Unnamed for a while, unable to say anything more.

Then I looked at the muscles writhing beneath his loose robes and became certain.

This bastard eats meat too.

Just look at those muscles. There was no way he had built a physique like that on temple vegetable bibimbap[1271] alone.

He would have to roast an entire pig whenever he got bored, and even his bibimbap[1272] would have to be beef-tartare bibimbap.[1273]

Shaolin Temple? More like the Temple of Wine Pools and Meat Forests.[1274]

Whoever said you couldn’t predict even an inch ahead in the Murim had been absolutely right.

Shaking my head, I followed the others into the Buddha hall.

The interior of the Buddha hall was small and old, but it had an elegant, antique charm.

The floor was spotless, and Buddha statues of every size stood throughout the hall.

[1271] *Bibimbap* is a Korean dish of rice mixed with vegetables and other toppings.

[1272] *Bibimbap* is a Korean dish of rice mixed with vegetables and other toppings.

[1273] *Bibimbap* is a Korean dish of rice mixed with vegetables and other toppings.

[1274] “Wine pools and meat forests” is an image of lavish indulgence. The Korean phrase also plays on the word for a temple’s abbot.

Unnamed stepped away for a while, leaving Jeok Cheongang, Hong Dao, and me seated across from one another, emptying our teacups. The tea, brewed from some unknown herb, was bitter and astringent.

“This is no way to treat an honored guest. What is this?”

“What do you think? Tea leaves I grew myself.”

“Tea leaves? You?”

“I’m old enough to know better, so I decided it was time to give up ‘grain tea’[1275] as well. That was decades ago.”

“…”

For someone who had supposedly given it up, he seemed to have drunk enough alcohol to last a lifetime.

I couldn’t bring myself to say it aloud and merely tipped my cup back. Jeok Cheongang, on the other hand, gaped at him.

“Are you sick? Do you have some terminal disease?”

“A terminal disease… Perhaps I do, perhaps I don’t. I’m not sure myself.”

His answer was calm, but Jeok Cheongang’s face stiffened.

“Does that mean…?”

“We’ll discuss that later.”

Hong Dao lightly waved a hand to cut him off, then turned and stared intently at me.

“Now, then… Are you the Master of Morning Star?”

The Master of Morning Star.

I had first heard the phrase from Unnamed only half a day ago.

I assumed rumors about a Morning Star appearing in the Murim had spread through the usual gossip.

The rumor has already reached this far?

The name Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi was gaining popularity by the day, but I hadn’t expected even the Abbot of Shaolin to recognize me.

Having suddenly gone world-class, I smiled awkwardly.

“That’s too much praise. I’m not quite at that level yet.”

“You’re more obtuse than you look.”

“Excuse me?”

“Did I not call you the Master of Morning Star?”

Yes, but what does that mean?

Seeing my bewildered expression, Hong Dao smiled faintly.

“Benefactor, do you know what a Morning Star is?”

[1275] “Grain tea” is a euphemism for alcoholic drink made from grain.

"Uh, well… Don't people usually call those who distinguish themselves Morning Stars?"

"And?"

"…A star?"

"Exactly."

Hong Dao nodded and continued in a calm voice.

"I have observed the heavens for a very long time. Perhaps the effort was not entirely futile, for I eventually learned to see and read the heavenly patterns to some extent."

"The heavenly patterns…"

The events of the past half day suddenly flashed through my mind.

Unnamed had come looking for us on his master's orders, and the moment he saw me, he had called me the Master of Morning Star.

And what had Jeok Cheongang said? Ah, right.

What an uncanny dirty monk. He can still see a thousand ri[1276] without leaving his seat.

He hadn't guided us here using information gathered from other people. He had read the heavenly patterns.

If that's true, he's far beyond some fake fortune-teller.

Calling it prophecy wouldn't even be an exaggeration.

I sensed something unusual from Hong Dao and swallowed hard.

"So?"

"A Morning Star is like a firework. It shines brightly in the night sky, then fades with time. But this one was different."

Hong Dao pointed through the open doors of the Buddha hall, toward the distant north where Shanxi Province lay.

"One day, a new Morning Star rose in the north. Its light has yet to fade. No, it grows brighter with each passing day."

"…"

"People often compare humans to stars. I believe that Morning Star is you."

Whenever someone is born or dies after accomplishing something great, people rejoice or lament.

A new star has risen. Or a great star has fallen.

But the Morning Star that appeared this time is supposed to be me?

Hong Dao clearly meant it as something good.

Still, I wasn't sure what to make of it.

[1276] This uses the Korean *ri*, approximately 393 m (0.244 mi). A thousand *ri* is about 393 km (244 mi).

Just as I scratched the back of my head with a perplexed expression, one of Hong Dao's words pierced my ears.

"That was four months ago."

"…!"

My entire body tingled as though I had been struck by electricity.

My mouth went dry, and my heart pounded. One thought spun endlessly through my mind.

Four months ago?

If it was then…

That was around the time I had first awakened in the Murim.

Hong Dao smiled warmly at me as I swallowed dryly.

"You seem to have something in mind."

"N-no. Nothing at all."

Jeok Cheongang, who had been listening silently, cut in with a disgusted look.

"It's written all over your face, you idiot."

"I-it really isn't."

"Oh? Shall I rip out that tongue of yours?"

"W-why are you doing this to me?"

Damn it. My tongue wouldn't stop tripping over itself.

Hong Dao burst into laughter as I slowly edged my bottom away from Jeok Cheongang to avoid his sharp gaze.

"It seems the benefactor is in urgent need of the privy. You may leave."

"Go on—if you want me to shove you into the latrine."

I looked back and forth between the two of them, then bolted for the door.

Behind me, I heard Hong Dao's booming laughter and Jeok Cheongang's shouts.

"Ha! Ha-ha-ha!"

"What an ill-mannered brat. How dare he run off while his master is speaking…"

Hong Dao looked at the grumbling Jeok Cheongang.

"Is he the Disciple you recently took in?"

Jeok Cheongang flinched and hurriedly cleared his throat.

"Ahem. Kheh-hem! He isn't my Disciple. He begged and pleaded for me to teach him a thing or two, so I'm merely looking after him for a while. Yes. That's all."

"Is that so?"

"I told you it is!"

"If that's the case, why are you shouting? You'll anger the Buddhas."

"Hah. Listen to the way this dirty monk talks."

Ignoring Jeok Cheongang's reaction, Hong Dao drained his teacup in one gulp and grimaced.

"Ugh, bitter. Hurry and finish yours."

"Finish this crap? Why would I drink something so bitter?"

"How can I pour the liquor if your cup isn't empty?"

"What?"

"I've been saving something for a day like this."

With a sly smile thoroughly unbecoming of a monk, Hong Dao rose and approached the row of Buddha statues.

He effortlessly lifted aside the largest statue, fumbled behind it, and pulled out a small earthenware jar.

"Snake liquor aged for thirty years."

"Snake liquor?"

"The Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake. Have you heard of it?"

"The Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes lit up.

He hurriedly opened the tightly sealed jar. Sure enough, the snake inside was larger than a python, with a horn protruding from its triangular head.

A poisonous aura strong enough to make his nose tingle poured from the jar. Jeok Cheongang stared in amazement.

"Isn't this thing lethally venomous? Where did you catch it?"

Hong Dao gazed off toward the distant mountains.

"While I was out for a walk."

"…You must have searched the whole mountain with the intention of making snake liquor from the start. There are limits to being a dirty monk. Now you're killing things just to have a drink?"

"If you don't want any, never mind. I'll drink it myself."

"Now, now."

Jeok Cheongang gave Hong Dao a pointed glare, then muttered, "Still, this thing's venom must be no joke…"

"Indeed. A single drop of venom squeezed from a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake can kill a hundred cows."

"It's been in there for thirty years. At this point, that's not liquor. It's poison."

"We only broke the seal for a moment, and already this much poisonous energy has spread through the air. What more is there to say?"

"Something this strong would kill even a decent master, wouldn't it?"

"It would be madness to drink it. We absolutely shouldn't."

Their gazes met in midair.

Then they spoke almost simultaneously.

“Then we have to drink it.”

“Of course. Absolutely.”

“Surely it won’t kill us.”

“Drink. We’re drinking it no matter what. I read the heavenly patterns, and today isn’t the day we die.”

Both men were over a hundred years old, yet neither could escape the simple recklessness etched deep into every man’s bones.

Before long, they were passing the jar back and forth and guzzling the liquor as though possessed.

Half a shichen[1277] later, early darkness had settled over the mountain, and the jar was empty.

“Ooh, that venomous tingle on the tip of the tongue gives it an incredible kick. Thanks to my Scorching Yang Qi, the poison can’t even touch me.”

Jeok Cheongang licked up the very last drop while Hong Dao glared at him.

Though both men numbered among the Ten Kings, a slight difference in skill still existed.

Hong Dao had lost out in the grappling technique they used to wrestle the jar away from each other, so he had not managed to drink even half of what it contained.

“An old brute with nothing but strength. No wonder you’ve lived so long.”

“Were you hoping I’d die?”

“I at least expected you to clutch your stomach and roll around.”

Pleasantly drunk, Jeok Cheongang burst into laughter.

“That’s what the heavenly patterns said, isn’t it? What can you do when Heaven has decided your lifespan?”

“The heavenly patterns…”

Hong Dao murmured the words, then casually added, “That was a lie.”

“Hm? What do you mean?”

“Exactly what I said. I’ve been slowly going blind for the past thirty years.”

“W-wait. Are you saying you can no longer read the heavenly patterns?”

Hong Dao nodded silently, and Jeok Cheongang’s heart sank.

“How did it happen? Is it because of your age?”

“At first, I thought so too. But I was mistaken. I gave up the liquor I loved so much and secluded myself in the wilderness to calm my mind, yet nothing changed.”

“Then…”

“It isn’t because this old man’s faculties have grown dull.”

Hong Dao sighed and raised his head.

[1277] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a *shichen* is about one hour.

Though the ceiling of the Buddha hall blocked his view, the old monk's profound gaze seemed to pierce straight through it.

"The heavenly patterns are becoming distorted. Drawing closer, and moving faster."

"…!"

"Then, amid all that, a Morning Star rose. Even in those chaotic heavens, its light was unmistakably clear."

Jeok Cheongang's eyelids trembled.

"And?"

Hong Dao considered the question for a long moment, then shook his head.

"That is all I can say. Though the heavenly patterns are in turmoil, they still retain their form, and the great trees rooted throughout the realm will not be easily shaken. However…"

An inscrutable light entered Hong Dao's eyes.

The words that followed carried the wisdom of a sage—of the current Abbot of Shaolin, the sect hailed for a thousand years as the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim,[1278] and of a man deeply versed in the study of the heavens.

"An unknown calamity is approaching. Dark clouds will roll in from somewhere, covering the sun and swallowing the stars."

A sky steeped in darkness, without a single ray of light.

Imagining it, Jeok Cheongang let one word slip out like a groan.

"Dark Heaven?"

"Dark Heaven. Yes, it will become just as you said—"

Jeok Cheongang hastily cut him off.

"No, that's not what I meant. I remembered something Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, told me."

"Jin Wikyung? I don't know who that is, but are you saying he predicted this situation as well?"

"More accurately, it appeared before them. I saw it with my own eyes."

Jeok Cheongang gave Hong Dao a detailed account of what had happened seven days and nights earlier, just before he left the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

He told him about the surviving remnants of the Head Elder's faction, who were still alive despite the restrictions placed on them, and about everything that had happened up to that point. He also told him about the mysterious pill called the Temporary Strength Pill that he had taken from Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader.

[1278] "Mount Tai and Northern Dipper" is a traditional honorific for a preeminent authority; Mount Tai is a mountain in China, and the Northern Dipper is a group of stars.

Jin Wikyung had passed all those facts to Jeok Cheongang, and Jeok Cheongang now passed them to Hong Dao.

“It was astonishing. The restrictions placed on them were so complex that even I couldn’t easily break them, and the effects of that Temporary Strength Pill were bizarrely powerful.”

“To think such a thing happened…”

“The hidden force that manipulated the Blade of Flowers from the shadows for decades. They are Dark Heaven.”

“Ngh…”

When the story ended, Hong Dao let out a low groan and sank into thought.

A long time passed before he finally spoke.

“Leave immediately.”

“…!”

“It seems the time has come for each of us to do what we must. I will devote all my strength to preparing for this calamity, and you…”

Jeok Cheongang gazed deeply at his old friend and finished the sentence.

“You must stay beside the Morning Star. So it doesn’t fade easily.”

Jeok Cheongang knew his task did not end there. He had to protect that light while helping it shine even brighter.

Having realized their respective duties, neither man hesitated any longer.

“I’ll be going.”

“I won’t see you off. We’ll save the rest of our reunion for another time.”

Their separation had been long, and their reunion short.

Jeok Cheongang smiled at Hong Dao one last time, then strode out of the Buddha hall without hesitation.

Remembering the words he had not managed to finish saying.

It was a short meeting, but I enjoyed it.

Late that night, the young man and the old man left Shaoshi Peak on Mount Song.

They continued walking until the sun rose and set once more.

Chapter 233

The middle-aged man gazed down at the crystal-clear blade.

Blade-sharp features and tightly pressed lips stared back at him. Strands of white had begun to appear here and there in his reflected hair.

After a while, he suddenly spoke.

“You’ve had a long wait.”

His low but powerful voice echoed through the spacious room. Yet no one stood anywhere within sight.

The answer came from the ceiling above his head.

“It is my duty.”

The whisper belonged to the person known as the Hidden Thread. There had been a Hidden Thread in the previous generation, and the generation before that. The position had existed for hundreds of years, ever since the family was founded.

Sworn to absolute loyalty toward one person alone—the Family Head—they were, true to their name, threads hidden from sight.

The countless pieces of information that flowed along those threads could be quietly forgotten—or turned into weapons with which to strangle someone.

“Do you have any new information?”

“Yes. Heaven-grade.”

“Heaven-grade.”

The middle-aged man ran a finger along the blade.

Every report the Hidden Thread delivered was confidential, but they were divided by importance into Heaven, Earth, and Human grades.

Heaven-grade was the highest of them all.

Even for a man who had led his family for nearly twenty years, such reports were exceedingly rare.

“It has been a while. Is this the first since the Huangshan Sect?”

The Huangshan Sect was a prestigious sect with a long history. Yet now, its name was slowly fading from the memories of the people.

Survival of the fittest.

The Murim was a merciless world that did not look back at those who had been weeded out. The middle-aged man had weeded out the Huangshan Sect and feasted on their corpses.

“There should still be a long time left before they reopen their gates.”

“The Huangshan Sect has already collapsed. Even if it reopened its gates, it could never recover.”

“Then?”

“The Mountain Lord has returned.”

The fingers caressing the blade abruptly stopped.

“…Is that true?”

“Without a doubt.”

The Mountain Lord—the master of the mountain.

Some might wonder what sort of nonsense that was. There were countless mountains under heaven, so what sense did it make to speak of their owner?

But here in Anhui Province, the title Mountain Lord referred to only one man.

“Fire King Jeok Cheongang…”

An unparalleled master who had faced a thousand martial artists alone.

Mount Jiuhua was his domain and the sacred ground of the Fire Gate Clan, whose legacy stretched back hundreds of years.

On the day the Demonic Cultists set fire to Mount Jiuhua, an old man who had been aging like any other became the Fire King.

The people of Anhui Province, who had protected their precious home thanks to him, began calling him the Mountain Lord out of respect.

“When and where did the report come from?”

“He passed through the North Gate two shichen[1279] ago.”

“His destination?”

“Mount Jiuhua.”

“I see.”

The middle-aged man nodded slightly, then sensed something odd.

Since becoming Family Head, he had received countless reports from the Hidden Thread and asked for his assessments, but the man had never once spoken with such certainty.

This time was different.

Sensing his lord’s question, the Hidden Thread spoke first.

“He was accompanied by his Disciple. Going to his sect is only natural.”

“His Disciple?”

The middle-aged man frowned. The Fire Gate Clan passed its teachings from one master to a single Disciple. The Fire King could have only one.

Though it had happened nearly twenty years ago, he clearly remembered everything concerning the Fire King.

“Did he come back for that vicious bastard?”

“It is not the man you are thinking of. According to confirmed reports, he died three months ago.”

“And the Fire King found a new Disciple?”

[1279] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

"Yes."

The Hidden Thread's flat voice continued.

"Jin Taekyung. He turned twenty-one this year and belongs to the direct line of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Both the name and the family are unfamiliar to me."

"He shares a bloodline with the Blade of Flowers, who distinguished himself during the Great Faction War, and the Heaven Shaking Sword, who has recently risen to prominence as one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes."

"Ah, that Jin Family."

"Yes."

Fortunately, the two names given by the Hidden Thread were familiar enough to the middle-aged man.

"Hmm. So that is how it is."

He sank into thought, forgetting even the Hidden Thread's presence.

Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Fire King Jeok Cheongang's new Disciple. No matter how much he considered it, the name remained unfamiliar.

But now he would have to become accustomed to it.

The Fire King chose a descendant of a frontier martial family.

He would never have accepted a man already past twenty as his new Disciple without good reason.

It must be one of two things. Either he has some leverage over the Fire King, or his martial talent is so extraordinary that his age and background are irrelevant.

The longer he considered it, the clearer the answer became.

A considerable amount of time had passed by the time he spoke again.

"Set every Lesser Thread in motion."

The Lesser Threads were the countless informants serving beneath the Hidden Thread.

They gathered information from all across the realm, which flowed through the Hidden Thread before reaching the middle-aged man.

"Every one of them?"

For the first time, a faint trace of surprise entered the Hidden Thread's voice.

The order meant focusing most of the family's intelligence network on a single person.

But his surprise lasted only a moment. Remembering his duty, the Hidden Thread quickly answered.

"Forgive my insolence."

"It doesn't matter. I'll give you a month. Use whatever means necessary and learn everything there is to know about that Disciple."

"As you command."

"You'll be busy for a while."

The Hidden Thread grasped the meaning behind those words, and his presence vanished as though it had been wiped clean.

His concealment technique had reached the very limits of the Peak realm. He would spend the next fortnight without a moment to breathe.

I can't sit idle either.

The middle-aged man slowly rose.

Unlike his father, who had been a martial artist to the bone, he had been born to lead.

He had guided the family since his days as Lesser Family Head, cementing its position as a dominant power. Authority radiated from his entire bearing.

Step. Step. Step.

He crossed the spacious room in long strides and threw open the doors. The dozen or so guards surrounding the pavilion dropped to one knee in greeting.

"We greet the Family Head!"

The middle-aged man nodded slightly. Every one of them was an outstanding Peak swordsman and a blood relative who shared his lineage.

They were a vast clan united beneath the surname Namgung—a great tree rooted deep in the Murim.

"Gather the clan. The weather is fine, so we should all share a drink."

"As you command!"

The middle-aged man, Namgung Ryong, raised his head toward the sky.

The boundless azure heaven stretched above him, not a single cloud in sight.

I spoke with the most solemn expression I could muster.

"I have a wish I've cherished for a long time."

Jeok Cheongang answered in an equally grave voice.

"This old man has a wish as well."

"If it wouldn't be too rude, may I go first?"

"That would be extremely rude."

"Then I'll be rude just this once."

"Want to have an accident in your pants? Should I make you piss and shit yourself for the rest of your life, not just this once?"

"…Ah."

My mother would have been devastated if she had seen this.

I could have cried at how unfair it was, but I held back my tears and tried again.

"Please hear me out just once."

“Fine. I know exactly what you’re after, but I’ll hear you out once.”

I swallowed dryly and stated my wish.

“Could we stop at an inn just once?”

“That’s your wish?”

“Yes.”

“Then this old man will tell you his.”

Jeok Cheongang glared at me with terrifying eyes.

“Shut your mouth and follow me.”

“…Why?”

“Didn’t you say you wanted to train? We’re on our way to train, so what are you whining about?”

“When did I say I didn’t want to? I’m going to be stuck in the mountains for the next six months. All I’m asking is that we eat our fill and wash up once—just once—before that!”

My shout echoed through the darkened mountains.

That was right. We were standing at the foot of Mount Jiuhua in Anhui Province.

“It took seven days and nights to get from Shanxi Province to Henan, then another seven days and nights to get from Henan to Anhui. I haven’t even slept properly.”

At least before we reached Henan, he had let me sleep for a shichen[1280] at a time. After we left Hong Dao’s residence, however, he had shown me absolutely no mercy.

We ran and ran, chewing jerky without even stopping for meals.

“I wanted to eat Shaolin Temple’s wild-vegetable bibimbap[1281]!”

During the fifteen-day forced march, the only proper meal I’d had was at the inn in Luoyang.

“And even then, you ate all the drumsticks! You left me one wing and nothing but dry breast meat!”

I had barely gotten to tear off a few pieces of meat when some sword-wielding dark-path figures showed up and ruined everything. Then the Under Armour monk appeared and took me to Shaolin Temple.

“I kept asking you to stop at an inn. What did you say? That we were almost there. That we could rest when we arrived!”

“And here we are. Mount Jiuhua.”

Jeok Cheongang dug into his ear with a grimy pinky nail, then blew the earwax away.

“Go up and rest. Once we’re there, you can eat your fill, wash, and sleep.”

[1280] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

[1281] *Bibimbap* is a Korean dish of rice mixed with vegetables and other toppings.

"Eating my fill just means jerky and fasting pills. Forget hot water—I'll get nothing but a nonstop forest bath. And you won't even let me sleep for half a shichen[1282] a day!"

"Hahaha!"

Jeok Cheongang laughed heartily, then stopped dead. At the same time, a chilling energy seeped from his entire body.

"This is why I don't like youngsters with sharp instincts."

"…!"

Big Brother Ed…

Wait, no.

Goose bumps raced down my spine.

His voice came out cold as ice.

"Yes, you guessed correctly. I intend to let you sleep for half a shichen[1283] a day and work you like a dog."

"Gasp!"

"I'll use fasting pills to squeeze every last drop of fat from your body. Then, for six months straight, I'll put you through the most extreme training humanly imaginable, without missing a single day."

"Y-you devil."

"Did you just call this old man a demon? I suppose I'll have to make your training even harder."

"N-no. This is a scam."

"Why don't you understand that by the time you realize that, it's already too late?"

"Wait. I need to visit the privy for a moment."

As I slowly backed away, the Fire King extended a wrinkled palm toward me.

"You came of your own free will, but leaving isn't up to you."

Whoosh!

An overwhelming force I had never felt before became ropes that bound my entire body.

Neither my near-superhuman physical abilities nor my nearly one jiazi[1284] of internal energy could do a thing.

I tried to resist somehow, but it was already too late. Following the movement of his hand, my body floated into the air.

"Seizing an Object Through Empty Space?"

"If you recognize it, hurry over."

Whoosh!

[1282] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

[1283] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

[1284] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

The next moment, I shot toward Jeok Cheongang faster than an arrow. At the same time, one of his wrinkled fingers brushed a spot on my neck.

A sharp sting was followed by an ominous sound in my ear.

Beep!

SYSTEM

You have been struck by Pressure-Point Strike!
Your Sleep Acupoint has been struck. You cannot resist sleep!
5 seconds, 4 seconds, 3 seconds, 2 seconds...

Drowsiness swept over me with the System's countdown.

As my consciousness blurred, Jeok Cheongang's voice slowly receded into the distance.

"Today, I'll make a special exception and let you sleep for two shichen[1285]."

"..."

Well, fuck. How very generous.

I couldn't force the words from the tip of my tongue before sleep claimed me.

Snore. Snore.

"That young bastard is absurdly strong."

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue as he looked down at the peacefully sleeping Jin Taekyung.

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space and Pressure-Point Strike were not omnipotent. The amount of force they required varied depending on the opponent.

It was a good thing he had known what kind of person this young man was. If he had been caught off guard and his technique had been countered, he would have been utterly humiliated.

"It feels like only yesterday that I met him in Shanxi, yet he has already come this far... What a strange fellow."

Just as Jeok Cheongang let out a weary sigh, his vision suddenly blurred and the strength drained from his legs.

"Gasp!"

Thud.

He barely managed to regain his senses before grabbing hold of a nearby tree.

[1285] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

His heart pounded, and his mind snapped fully awake as though someone had dumped cold water over him in his sleep.

“Th-this…”

Had he expended too much strength at once? Or had his aged body failed to withstand the arduous journey?

Jeok Cheongang bit his lip. Although his prime as a martial artist had passed, he was still a Supreme Peak master who had reached the pinnacle of martial arts.

It wasn’t his body that had grown old. It was something else.

I must hurry. I don’t have much time.

Perhaps that was why his old friend Hong Dao had told him to leave immediately.

After steadying himself, Jeok Cheongang slung Jin Taekyung over his back. Though he was more than a hundred years old, the young man’s massive frame felt as light as a feather.

“Not yet. It can’t happen yet.”

He muttered in a voice that had suddenly grown much older, then set off.

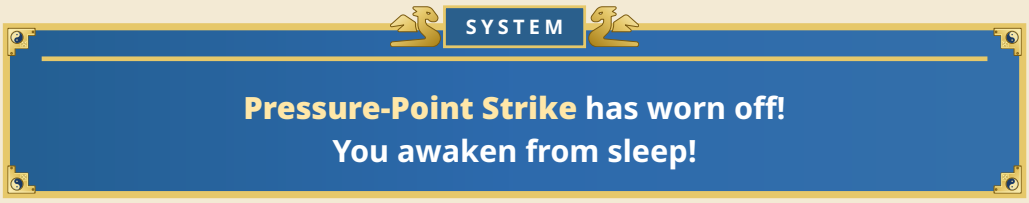
More than ten jang[1286] vanished beneath each step, and the scenery flashed past.

Before long, thick fog rolled in and erased every trace of him.

[1286] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

Chapter 234

Ding.



I opened my eyes as the System notifications appeared.

The first things I saw were the waves of branches rippling far below in the night wind and the stars scattered across the pitch-black sky. Cold, hard rock pressed against my back.

I'm outside.

I'd expected as much. Even a preschooler could have guessed that Jeok Cheongang wouldn't lay me down on a soft duck-down bed.

Besides, my body was sturdy enough to sleep anywhere.

Then why does my body feel so heavy?

Had I been pushing myself too hard lately?

System or not, apparently I was still human after all.

Maybe it was the fifteen-day forced march. My body felt as heavy as if I had an iron ball hanging from it…

Clank.

"Huh?"

Clank?

I turned toward the sound.

Manacles had been fastened tightly around my wrists and ankles, with chains connecting each of them to an iron ball.

"…They really are iron balls."

What the hell was this?

My brain stopped working for a few seconds. Who was I? Where was I?

And why were these ridiculous things locked onto my limbs?

The answer came quickly. It was an easier question than one plus one.

"Fire King!"

The shout burst from me like a thunderclap.

Smack!

"Ah!"

"What an insolent little bastard."

Jeok Cheongang, who had nailed me in the back of the head with a pebble, ambled toward me with his feet splayed.

"How dare you throw around my epithet in my presence? Am I your friend?"

I sprang to my feet after rolling across the rock in pain.

Clank.

"What is this?"

"That? An iron ball."

"I wasn't asking because I didn't know what it was."

"Then why ask when you already know?"

"…"

"From now on, these will be your arms and legs. They are training tools passed down through the Fire Gate Clan for generations, so treat them like your own children."

I was a virgin bachelor who had never even been in a relationship, let alone married, and he was talking about children?

Dumbfounded, I grabbed one of the chains attached to the iron balls and pulled.

Rattle.

I heard metal scraping and felt the tremendous weight behind it.

They were heavy enough that even a decent First Rate martial artist wouldn't be able to remain standing while wearing them.

"These are training tools passed down through the clan for generations?"

"Did this old man not just say so?"

"How much do they weigh?"

"Not much. About two hundred geun?"[1287]

"…"

"Oh, and that isn't their combined weight. Each one weighs two hundred geun."[1288]

Two hundred geun came to 120 kilograms even by modern standards.[1289]

With such monstrous things fastened to all four of my limbs, the total weight was…

About five hundred kilograms.[1290] *Half a ton.*

I thought for a moment, then opened my mouth.

"Have you gone senile?"

[1287] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to about 600 g (1.32 lb). Two hundred geun is about 120 kg (265 lb).

[1288] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to about 600 g (1.32 lb). Two hundred geun is about 120 kg (265 lb).

[1289] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to about 600 g (1.32 lb). Two hundred geun is about 120 kg (265 lb).

[1290] The four iron balls weigh about 500 kg (1,100 lb) in total.

"…You really will say anything, won't you?"

I'd said it knowing I would probably get hit, but for some reason, that was the extent of Jeok Cheongang's reaction.

He stared at me with a complicated expression for a moment before continuing.

"Regardless, you'll live with those iron balls chained to you from now on. During training, of course, but also while sleeping and eating."

"Hmm."

"It's all part of your training."

"You're serious?"

"If you don't believe me, quit. I won't bother seeing you off."

Jeok Cheongang turned away without hesitation, and I hurriedly called after him.

"W-wait!"

"What? I thought you didn't want to do it."

"I haven't even answered yet. You can't just walk away."

"So what's your answer?"

"Well…"

Damn it. This is a serious internal conflict.

But once the initial shock of seeing the iron balls wore off, my mind gradually settled.

It's not impossible.

I had made it this far after narrowly escaping death dozens of times.

The world wasn't easy. To receive a reward, you had to pay a corresponding price. That was true in the Murim and in the modern world.

Everyone—not just me—lived through an endless series of Quests.

And…

If this were enough to make me turn back, I never would've come this far.

Compared to the fruit I would harvest in the future, this was a bargain.

Having made my decision, I met Jeok Cheongang's gaze.

"Fine. I'll do it."

"I can't hear you."

"I said I'll do it!"

"Ha-ha-ha! Good!"

A smile spread across Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled lips.

What a sly old man.

He had acted as if he didn't care either way, but I had known all along that deep down, he wanted me too.

"So what do I start with?"

"You want to begin right away?"

“They say to strike while the iron is hot. If I’m doing this anyway, I might as well start now.”

“You do have a bold streak. But first, you need to eat.”

“What? Why all of a sudden?”

“Do you think training means starving yourself? You need something in your stomach before you can accomplish anything worthwhile.”

I caught the object Jeok Cheongang pulled from inside his robe and tossed to me.

Under the faint moonlight, I peeled away the damp Korean paper to reveal a fasting pill[1291] with a reddish cast.

“You should’ve given me jerky instead.”

“Stop complaining and eat it. That isn’t an ordinary fasting pill.[1292] It was made using a secret Fire Gate Clan method.”

“What does it do?”

“It’s superior in every respect, but…”

“This stuff makes my stomach feel so bloated. Just looking at it kills my appetite now.”

“It’s especially good for your virility.”

“Wow. My mouth’s watering just looking at it.”

“…”

“I’ll enjoy the meal!”

If it was good for virility, I had to eat it. Even if I had no immediate use for it, I still had to eat it.

Thinking of the future, I chewed the fasting pill[1293] thoroughly and swallowed it.

Jeok Cheongang watched me intently before asking, “Finished?”

“Yes, Old Master.”

“Well? Feel anything?”

“I’m not sure. I think my sperm count may have gone up a little…”

Jeok Cheongang frowned at my answer and muttered, “Strange. Has it been sitting around so long that the medicine lost its potency?”

“Huh?”

What the hell was he talking about?

The moment I blurted out the question—

Ding.

[1291] A fasting pill, or *byeokgokdan*, is a food-substitute pill in martial arts fiction.
[1292] A fasting pill, or *byeokgokdan*, is a food-substitute pill in martial arts fiction.
[1293] A fasting pill, or *byeokgokdan*, is a food-substitute pill in martial arts fiction.

SYSTEM

You have taken Fire King's Special Restriction Pill.
You feel full!
Agility decreases by 100!
Strength decreases by 100!
Stamina decreases by 100!
You cannot use internal energy!
The effects will last for one week!

"...Huh?"

It happened without warning.

The instant the System notification appeared, strength drained from my arms and legs, and my breathing grew short.

Finally, the internal energy flowing steadily through the minor meridians throughout my body descended into my dantian. Then it became completely immobile, as though something had bound it in place.

"Guh!"

Thud!

With all my strength gone at once, my body, which had somehow been supporting the iron balls, sagged.

The half-ton weight[1294] pressing down on my entire body made my knees buckle.

"What the hell is this?"

"Heh-heh. The medicine is finally taking effect."

I stared at Jeok Cheongang, who was letting out a sinister laugh, with my jaw hanging open.

"What the hell did you do, you crazy old man?"

"What did you call me? A crazy old man?"

"Gasp. No, that's not what I meant."

"Let's see... Yes, that should do nicely for your first training exercise."

As soon as he finished speaking, he extended a wrinkled palm toward me.

An immense flow of qi filled the air. The fierce wind abruptly changed direction and began swirling around him.

A flash of insight struck me.

There's a cliff below this, isn't there?

I hurriedly glanced back. The view below the rock was dizzying.

If I fell from here with these insane iron balls attached to me...

"W-wait!"

[1294] The four iron balls weigh about 500 kg (1,100 lb) in total.

“Wait for what? Weren’t you the one who said we should strike while the iron was hot?”

“But that was—!”

“Too late.”

Fwoosh!

Compressed air exploded from Jeok Cheongang’s palm. The blast of fist wind, powerful enough to uproot rocks and trees, became a giant’s fist and slammed into me.

Against that powerful wind, even several hundred kilograms of iron balls[1295] were useless.

Boom!

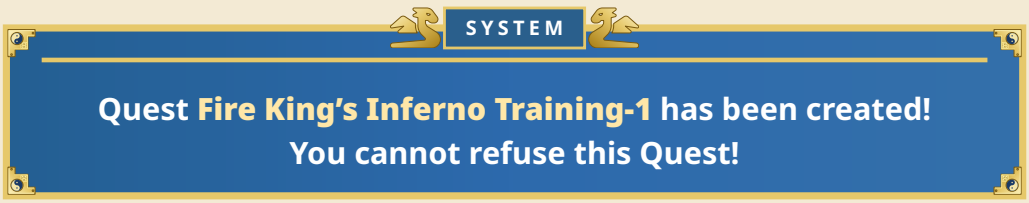
Ah, shit.

The next moment, the ground vanished beneath my feet, and I was flung into the air.

Through my upside-down vision, I saw Jeok Cheongang waving at me with a broad grin.

“You have one shichen[1296] to make it back up. If you’re even fifteen minutes late, you fail.”

Ding.



“This is fucking bullsh—!”

Before I could finish speaking, gravity bore down on my entire body.

As I plummeted like a streak of light, there was only one thing I could say.

“Aaaaaaaaaaah!”

My terrified scream shook Mount Jiuhua, submerged in darkness.

Splash—

Far below the sheer cliff, Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh at the sound of water echoing up from below.

A memory from his youth had suddenly come to mind.

“Master! Save me!”

[1295] The four iron balls weigh about 500 kg (1,100 lb) in total.

[1296] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

"I'm counting to three. Let go. Three."

"Please! If I fall from here, your Disciple will die!"

"Two."

"Master!"

"One."

His Master had been merciless—harsh enough to seem excessive toward a child who still had baby fuzz on his face.

But without such harsh instruction, neither the Fire Gate Clan of today nor Fire King Jeok Cheongang would exist.

I'll put you through exactly what I endured… No, I'll push you even harder.

Jin Taekyung didn't know it, but Jeok Cheongang did.

They did not have much time.

There was no time to teach him everything gradually, one step at a time.

The heavenly patterns[1297] Hong Dao had foreseen told him as much, as did Jeok Cheongang's current condition.

Hold out until then. This old man will do his best as well.

Jeok Cheongang gazed down the mountain for some time, his eyes unfathomably deep. Then he suddenly muttered, "…Perhaps I shouldn't have put the iron balls on him."

He had never imagined that the object meant to restrain criminals of the Fire Gate Clan would be used for something like this.

"Hngh. Hnnnngh!"

Grrrnk. Grrrnnngh.

With every step I took, the ground that had only just begun to thaw sank beneath me. Deep trenches formed in my wake.

But I was used to it by now. Sweat poured off me as I continued up the steep mountain path.

"Huff, huff."

Ding.

[1297] *Heavenly patterns* refers to celestial patterns studied for signs of major changes and omens.

SYSTEM

Extreme Training!
Endless effort never betrays you!
Strength, Stamina, and Agility have increased by 1 each!
Muscles and Bones and Sinews and Meridians have increased by 2 each!

Even a drizzle will soak you through eventually, so these stat increases, though small, helped more than you might think.

If only I didn't have these fucking iron balls! If only it weren't for that damn restriction pill!

Without either one, I would have completed the Quest long ago.

But my most important internal energy was restricted, my physical stats had each dropped by 100, and the tremendous weight had been added on top of that. I had no way to endure it.

To top it all off, the time limit was only one shichen.[1298]

Shit. Mount Jiuhua isn't some little hill behind the neighborhood.

It was so grueling that I had even considered breaking the chains connecting the iron balls.

That was before I learned they were made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

They used this stuff for chains? Were they insane?

In the end, I had no choice but to keep going through sheer stubbornness and grit.

One day, two days, three days, four days…

And finally, today—ten days later.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest Fire King's Hellfire Training-1 has been completed!
You acquired a substantial amount of EXP!
Level Up!
You acquired 30 Bonus Points!

With about fifteen minutes left before the deadline, I finally reached the summit.

Thud!

"Yaaaaaah!"

I let the heavy iron balls crash to the ground and released a roar from the depths of my lungs.

[1298] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

The sound startled Jeok Cheongang, who had been nodding off against a rock. He jolted awake.

“W-what happened?”

Damn old man. He was always going on about how martial artists shouldn’t waste time sleeping, yet he slept like a baby while I was going through hell?

Grinding my teeth, I walked toward him.

“Can’t you tell by looking? I climbed Mount Jiuhua within one shichen.[1299] I succeeded!”

“Huh? Why are you climbing Mount Jiuhua?”

“What?”

Jeok Cheongang blinked, then hastily shook his head.

“Ah, no. You did pretty well.”

“And?”

“It seems you’re ready for the next stage. I’ve already made the preparations, so take care of it yourself.”

I turned my head toward where his finger was pointing.

Propped against a massive rock was a vest—a huge, incredibly thick vest made of iron.

My fingertips began to tremble despite myself.

“…Is this what I think it is?”

“What were you thinking?”

“That I’m supposed to put this on and repeat exactly what I’ve been doing until now.”

“You rascal. What a joke.”

“Right? Wow, you scared the hell out of me.”

“Ha-ha. What an adorable imagination you have.”

Jeok Cheongang chuckled with the amiable smile of a kindly neighborhood grandfather, then continued.

“If you’ve managed one thing, you should accomplish at least two the next time. Come to think of it, one shichen[1300] was far too generous.”

“What?”

“I’ll give you half a shichen.[1301] Hurry up, pick it up, put it on, and get back here.”

“…”

Ding.

[1299] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[1300] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[1301] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

SYSTEM
Quest information has been changed!
Repeat Quest Fire King's Inferno Training-1 has been created!

Chapter 235

The training Jeok Cheongang put me through was simple.

Take a horse stance beneath the waterfall. Do push-ups. Go fetch me some bird eggs because I feel like eating them…

That much was fine. The problem was the conditions tacked onto every exercise.

“Six shichen[1302] in a horse stance.”

“You’re joking, right?”

“Does it sound like I’m joking?”

Whoosh!

The waterfall plunged hundreds of jang[1303]. Even with my exceptional physique, a single shichen beneath it left my entire body aching as though it had been smashed apart and my vision swimming.

And he wanted me to stay there for six shichen. In a horse stance, no less.

“Old Master, this is a bit much. If I stay under there for six shichen, I’ll actually die.”

“Have you tried it?”

“Huh?”

“Try it before you say that. If you don’t like it, go back to your family.”

It took me ten full days to complete the Quest.

As a side effect, I briefly lost consciousness. When I opened my eyes again, the iron balls had grown heavier.

“An additional hundred geun[1304]. From now on, we’re increasing it to twelve shichen.”

“…”

For a moment, I considered using Logout.

But I had to finish the training. It might have looked foolish to others, but it was a rule I had set for myself when I began.

If I go back, my body and mind will grow lax.

Whoosh!

The pressure of the waterfall was terrifying. With my internal energy and physical abilities restricted, I had to endure with nothing but my body and sheer willpower.

When I finally completed the waterfall training, I was left with legs harder than steel—and an unexpected System notification.

[1302] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[1303] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1304] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb).

SYSTEM

Fire King's Hellfire Training-2 has been completed successfully!
Outstanding achievement: Unmoving achieved!
Toughness changes to Endurance!
Level Up!
Level Up!
You acquired 50 Bonus Points!

The training continued without pause. I wasn't given any time to rest.

I got one shichen of blissful sleep each day. Everything else was part of my training.

"Next are push-ups."

"That's too easy. Wait. How many?"

"Ten thousand. Put the iron balls on your back."

"..."

It was the most hellish push-up routine in the world. But I gritted my teeth and did it.

On the day I completed every kind of push-up Jeok Cheongang wanted, the year's first sprouts were pushing up from the ground.

"The weather has grown warm. I feel like having a swallow's nest dish[1305] for once, so go fetch one."

"Aren't swallows migratory birds? They won't arrive until it gets warmer."

"What would an ignorant brat like you know? This old man has lived on Mount Jiuhua his entire life. By now, a few impatient swallows should be starting to build their nests."

"Whew. Where am I supposed to look for them?"

"Cliffs."

That Quest took the longest. I had to find a swallow's nest without even knowing where one might be.

By then, I was combing every cliff on Mount Jiuhua while laden with iron balls whose combined weight had long since surpassed a thousand geun[1306].

At last, I found a newly completed swallow's nest and brought it to Jeok Cheongang.

"Here it is. A swallow's nest."

His long silence was followed by a single muttered sentence that was more than enough to snap the last thread of my patience.

[1305] Edible bird's nest is an East Asian delicacy traditionally made with nests built by swiftlets.

[1306] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb).

"...It really exists."

"You fucking old bastard!"

My eyes rolled back, and I lunged at Jeok Cheongang. He beat me within an inch of my life.

When I came to again, the iron balls had grown heavier. That was only natural.

"If you're awake, get moving."

"Is this a new training routine?"

"It is. In a sense."

Jeok Cheongang thrust an insane schedule in front of me.

It included every single thing I had done so far, without exception.

"Three round trips up and down Mount Jiuhua in the morning, ten thousand one-armed push-ups on each side at noon. Climb the cliffs, then hold a horse stance beneath the waterfall... Human, are you insane?"

"Another five hundred geun[1307] if you don't like it."

"I've actually wanted to spend every day like this for a long time. I'll be right back."

"Good."

From then on, I did whatever he told me.

I wondered if it was even possible, but once I tried it, it turned out to be possible.

A day passes quickly when your body is exhausted. The more intense the training became, the faster time flew.

The frozen ground thawed, and fresh sprouts emerged.

Two months passed, but my daily routine remained unchanged. The only differences were that the training had become more brutal and the iron balls had grown heavier.

Rustle.

Flowers and grass that had already grown tall brushed against my calves.

High on a peak of Mount Jiuhua, now awash in color, Jeok Cheongang groggily opened his eyes. He had been asleep with his back against a tree.

"Is that you?"

"Who else would come looking for you besides me?"

"I thought you were the Grim Reaper."

"I think even the Grim Reaper would run away in fear."

Jeok Cheongang let out a short laugh at my wisecrack.

"You grow more flattering by the day."

[1307] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb).

“Yes, and you’ve been sleeping more by the day, Old Master.”

Just as I said, Jeok Cheongang had been sleeping much more often lately. Given his age, perhaps it was only natural.

“I was training.”

“Ah. In your dreams?”

“I was merely resting my eyes.”

“You were snoring.”

“…Ahem. More importantly, what are you doing here instead of training?”

“I’m finished.”

“Already?”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyes widened slightly.

“I wasn’t slacking off, so don’t give me that suspicious look.”

“Who said anything? Fine. Shut your mouth and work on your fists and feet.”

“Yes, sir.”

I promptly took up a stance in a nearby clearing.

Unlike with the spear, I was practically a beginner when it came to fists and feet, so I was still working on the fundamentals.

“You know what you’re supposed to do, right?”

“Yes, yes.”

Ding.

I began with the simplest straight punch.

Each movement came with the insane requirement of a thousand repetitions, but compared to everything I had already done, it was easy.

The fact that I think this is easy means I’m going insane too.

I let out a deep sigh and began throwing punches.

Whoosh! Bam!

The wind split around my fists, and compressed air burst outward.

In the past, I had simply relied on strength, speed, and internal energy. Now I could execute each movement precisely and control the amount of force behind it.

Clatter!

How long had I listened to the chains connected to my wrists sway and rattle? I kept driving my fists into an imaginary point without pause until I heard a System notification in my ear.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Repeat Quest Fist-and-Foot Training has been completed successfully!
Flawless movements without a single error!
Strength, Stamina, and Agility have each increased by 1!
You have not yet learned fist-and-foot martial arts. Additional rewards will be granted when you acquire a related martial art in the future!

The repeat Quest gave worthwhile rewards. They diminished with each repetition, but even this much was more than enough to be grateful for.

I could probably do this another two or three times.

No Quest, no reward.

I relaxed my stance and walked over to Jeok Cheongang. Just as before, he was leaning against the tree, looking in my direction.

“Old Master. I’m finished.”

“…”

“Old Master.”

“Uh… huh?”

He snapped awake and looked up at me.

“What is it?”

“I finished the fist-and-foot training.”

“What did you finish?”

“The fist-and-foot training. Fists and feet!”

“What are you talking about?”

“You told me to do it about a shichen ago.”

“What?”

Jeok Cheongang furrowed his brow.

“When did I do that?”

“Huh?”

“Why are you suddenly spouting such nonsense? This old man has been sitting here watching you with both eyes wide open.”

“…”

What the hell is going on here?

Utterly bewildered, I asked, “Why are you doing this to me?”

“What?”

“Are you doing this on purpose to make me train more? You didn’t have to go this far. I was planning to keep training anyway.”

“What kind of nonsense are you spouting?”

Jeok Cheongang was about to erupt in anger when he suddenly closed his mouth.

For an instant, unknowable emotions passed across his wrinkled face. After a long silence, he finally spoke.

“You’re a perceptive one. If you’ve figured it out, go practice your fists and feet some more.”

Ding. A notification appeared, telling me that another Quest had been created, but I didn’t move an inch.

I stared at Jeok Cheongang for a long moment before suddenly opening my mouth.

“Old Master. I just want to ask you something.”

Jeok Cheongang’s shrewd gray eyes trembled.

The suspicion that had crossed my mind—*Could it be?*—hardened into certainty.

“Are you feeling unwell?”

It wasn’t an easy subject to bring up, so I had phrased it indirectly. But there was no doubt he understood what I meant.

After a suffocating silence, a sigh-like word escaped Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

“…Follow me. There is somewhere we need to go together.”

Dementia.

Even in the modern world, with all its advances in magical medicine, dementia remained impossible to cure completely.

Its progression could only be slowed. Everyone was equal before the curse of time.

Why didn’t I realize it?

Thinking back, there had definitely been warning signs. He had been sleeping more with each passing day, and I had noticed bouts of forgetfulness like the one just now several times before.

Even so, I hadn’t been particularly suspicious because he wasn’t an ordinary old man.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

I had never imagined that a Supreme Peak master whose martial arts had reached the heavens could suffer from the infirmities of old age.

Perhaps it was a truth that even Jeok Cheongang himself wanted to deny.

“The history of our sect stretches back hundreds of years.”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice echoed through the cave.

It was as hot and humid as a steam sauna inside, and the heat intensified the deeper we went.

I had already been staying on Mount Jiuhua for more than two months, but I had never once visited this place.

“Our founding ancestor was the greatest under heaven of his era. However, his forthright nature earned him many enemies.”

His calm voice continued like flowing water.

He told me the history of the Fire Gate Clan from its founding to the present day.

From the first Sect Leader to Jeok Cheongang’s master, the seventeenth Sect Leader.

Some had ventured into the Murim and made their names known throughout the world. Others had spent their entire lives secluded in the countryside, quietly raising their successors.

Countless sects had disappeared over the past several hundred years, but the Fire Gate Clan had preserved its lineage.

“Even that became uncertain in this old man’s generation. It is all due to my lack of virtue.”

After about half an hour, we finally stopped walking.

By then, my entire body was drenched in sweat from the heat radiating beyond a moss-covered stone gate.

“This place is…”

“The Fire Gate Cavern. This is where our sect began, and where its legacy continues.”

Jeok Cheongang gazed at the stone gate with a nostalgic expression before placing his palm against its surface.

The instant the Scorching Yang Qi flowing from his fingertips touched the gate, an intricately engraved sun emblem began to glow. The firmly sealed stone door slowly slid open.

“…Whoa.”

I stared into the Fire Gate Cavern, entranced.

The space was several times larger than the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s training hall. Seventeen urns stood around a blue-white flame.

It wasn’t difficult to guess what they contained.

The former Sect Leaders of the Fire Gate Clan.

They were probably funeral urns holding their remains. As if confirming my guess, Jeok Cheongang immediately prostrated himself before them.

“Your unworthy Disciple, Jeok Cheongang, pays his respects to the Sect Ancestors.”

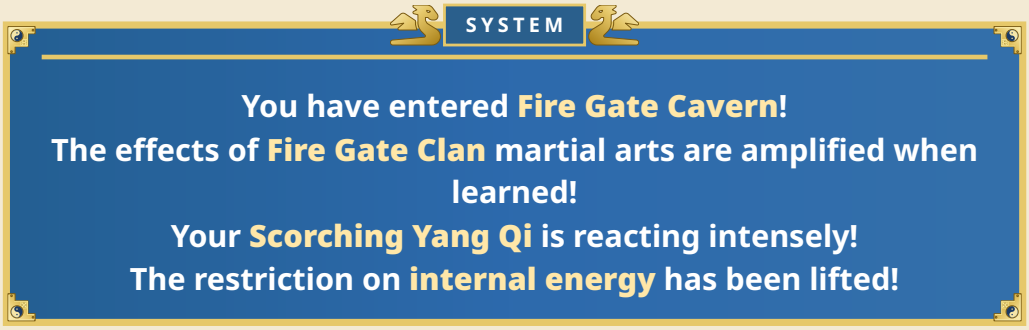
He rose and beckoned to me.

“Come in.”

“Ah, yes. Excuse me.”

The instant I carefully stepped into the Fire Gate Cavern, a System notification pierced my ears.

Ding.



Hummm.

The internal energy in my dantian, awakened from its long slumber, spread through my limbs and body.

Seeing my astonishment, Jeok Cheongang spoke as though he had expected this.

“Your internal energy comes from the Blazing Flame Divine Pill. It is only natural that it would react to the Fire Gate Cavern.”

It found its roots. Is that it?

It was a strange feeling. My internal energy surged like a living creature, and my heart pounded along with it. Though this was my first time setting foot here, the place felt strangely familiar.

“Sit.”

We sat facing each other with the flame between us.

Beyond the blue-white fire, Jeok Cheongang’s face looked noticeably older.

“I will pass on our sect’s martial arts to you.”

“…!”

“What? Did you think I would suddenly tell you to become my Disciple?”

“To be honest… yes, I did.”

“A master and Disciple are not bound together out of necessity or coercion. Besides, this old man already suffers from the infirmities of old age. Learning from me will place you in great danger as well.”

Everything Jeok Cheongang said was perfectly reasonable.

If he became confused about the formula of an internal cultivation technique, if he forgot even a single word, I would cross an irreversible river.

The river of qi deviation—or death.

“Can you learn martial arts from someone like me?”

I took a deep breath.

Only after turning it over from every angle did I finally reach a single conclusion.

“I will.”

"I'll say it again…"

"I trust you, Old Master. That's enough."

For a moment, Jeok Cheongang was speechless as indescribable emotions crossed his face.

Then a smile spread across his wrinkled lips.

"Then we are alike in that regard."

One-person succession, passed only to the worthy.

For hundreds of years, the Fire Gate Clan's legacy had been entrusted to a single talented individual who could be trusted not to use it for evil.

The fact that Jeok Cheongang had brought me here, to the Fire Gate Cavern, meant that he already trusted me.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang trusts me. He chose me. He intends to pass everything the Fire Gate Clan has to me.

My heart swelled at the thought. As though it had sensed my emotions, the blue-white flame surged violently.

Ding.

Along with the System notification, Jeok Cheongang reached out his hand. As Seizing an Object Through Empty Space took effect, the lid of a dark metal box that had risen from the flames opened.

I read the title of the old book floating toward me.

"Fire Gate Divine Technique…"

I knew instinctively that this martial art was the foundation of the Fire Gate Clan—practically its entire legacy.

Jeok Cheongang had risen to his feet and now stood directly behind me.

"We'll begin at once, so sit cross-legged and close your eyes. From now on, circulate your energy according to the formula I teach you."

I followed his instructions and closed my eyes. In the darkness, the blue-white flame seemed to flicker before me.

At last, Jeok Cheongang's voice pierced my ears.

"What about your fist-and-foot training?"

"…Huh?"

"Did you finish your training and start slacking off? Wait, fuck, that startled me. This is the Fire Gate Cavern. What the hell is this?"

"…!"

Oh, fuck. Dementia…

After that day, the two people who had caused such a commotion on Mount Jiuhua for some time vanished without a trace.

While they were gone, the trees sprouted green leaves, the flowers bloomed in full, and the swallows built their nests along the cliffs.

From green, to autumn foliage, and then to white snow.

Until Mount Jiuhua changed its clothes three times.

Chapter 236

The man gazed at the Four Treasures of the Study, neatly arranged before him.

The brush was made from sable fur, the inkstone from bluish jade, and the ink and paper were tribute goods said to be used by the royal family of Haedong,[1308] ten thousand *li*[1309] away.

Every piece was of the finest quality, beyond the means of anyone but the wealthiest.

“Excellent. Simply excellent.”

A satisfied smile spread across his face. The man was famous for his frugality, and the Four Treasures of the Study were the one luxury he allowed himself.

“Well, then. Shall we begin?”

Just as he began happily grinding his ink, the door opened and someone strode toward him without hesitation.

“Anyone who saw you would think you were a Hanlin Academician.[1310]”

The uninvited guest was a martial artist covered in dust.

He had narrow, sharply slanted eyes and a well-worn sword at his waist. At the sight of him, the man made a show of hardening his expression.

“A Hanlin Academician?[1311] I’d rather you call me a master painter.”

“You still paint?”

“It’s my only pleasure.”

“Unfortunately, you don’t exactly look the part. Would you care to learn some martial arts from me?”

“I must respectfully decline. This is as far as my abilities as a martial artist will ever take me.”

“What a shame. You lack the qualities a martial artist ought to possess.”

“It doesn’t matter. I have a subordinate who’s astonishingly good with a sword. Why else would his epithet be Ghost Sword?”

At the man’s sly response, the uninvited guest’s expression slowly relaxed.

A moment later, as if by prior agreement, they both let out quiet laughs.

“My lord, you haven’t changed.”

“Neither have you, Wipeng.”

They had not seen each other in four whole months, making the reunion all the more welcome.

[1308] Haedong is a traditional name for Korea.

[1309] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

[1310] A Hanlin Academician was a scholar appointed to an imperial Chinese court.

[1311] A Hanlin Academician was a scholar appointed to an imperial Chinese court.

Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, smiled broadly as he clapped Wipeng on the shoulder.

"What brings you here without any warning? The messenger pigeon said you wouldn't arrive until noon tomorrow."

"The Jin Dragon Squad can manage perfectly well without me."

The Jin Dragon Squad was currently the Jin Family of Taiyuan's foremost fighting force.

It had been established only a year ago, but every member possessed impressive martial skills, and their loyalty to the family was even greater.

The fact that Wipeng, Jin Wikyung's trusted subordinate, served as its Commander spoke volumes about the squad's standing.

"You didn't slip away on your own without telling anyone, did you? You are the Commander."

"Of course not. I left that Hyuk fellow in charge. He'll manage just fine."

"The acting Deputy Commander?"

"Yes."

"This was his first mission, wasn't it? What did you think after watching him?"

Wipeng's eyebrow twitched.

He had thought he was getting used to Hyuk Mujin, but merely thinking about the man made his head ache.

Still, merit was merit, and personal feelings were personal. He answered with a sigh.

"He's useful enough. Aside from the fact that he never stops running his mouth."

"I already had some idea, but he sounds even more cheerful than I expected."

"He's so goddamn cheerful it's a problem."

"What about everything else?"

"…If you teach him one thing at a time, he learns quickly."

"If you're saying that, he must possess considerable martial talent."

A year earlier, Hyuk Mujin had been granted the honor of joining the Jin Dragon Squad in recognition of his service.

Naturally, Jin Taekyung's influence had also played a part in that decision.

That fellow is better than he looks. Try training him.

Jin Wikyung had always had a soft spot for his younger brothers.

Thinking Taekyung might be right, he had placed Hyuk Mujin in the Jin Dragon Squad and assigned Wipeng to train him. Sure enough, the young man's skills improved by the day.

His cheeky, easygoing nature helped him get along well with the other members, and there was no question about his loyalty.

"Ha-ha-ha! As expected of our youngest—he has an eye for people."

Jin Wikyung laughed heartily. At some point, a bottle of liquor had appeared in his hand.

He filled a cup to the brim, handed it over, and spoke.

“In any case, you’ve worked hard. So, is everything in Northern Gaoyuan settled now?”

“Yes. There shouldn’t be any trouble for at least the next ten years.”

The stabilization of Northern Gaoyuan.

That was why Wipeng had been away from the Jin Family of Taiyuan for the past four months.

Jin Wikyung believed that to become the true hegemon of Shanxi Province, he first needed to subjugate Gaoyuan’s mounted bandits. After months of secret and meticulous preparation, he had unleashed his sharpest weapon against them.

The sword known as Ghost Sword Wipeng.

“We attacked from seven directions, and they collapsed without putting up any meaningful resistance.”

The Murim of Shanxi—particularly the sects and merchant groups in the northern region, which had suffered the worst damage—welcomed the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s bold decision and actively cooperated.

The so-called Seven-Route Army was formed with Wipeng and the Jin Dragon Squad at its forefront. With the merchants’ full support, they were equipped with quality weapons and warhorses.

Powerful reinforcements also joined the campaign.

“The Lower District Sect was frightening. I was reminded once again of how terrifying information can be.”

Having received a considerable share of the northern region’s interests immediately after the war, the Lower District Sect had welcomed Jin Wikyung’s decision with open arms.

Like the seasoned information merchants they were, they monitored the mounted bandits’ every move while spreading false information and laying traps.

Their thoroughness left even Jin Wikyung impressed.

“Everything in this world is put to different use depending on who wields it. The truly frightening one is Wolhwa. She isn’t meant to remain confined to Shanxi Province.”

“Is that so?”

“Can’t you tell from the results? Her true weapon isn’t her beauty. It’s her strategic mind.”

Two thousand.

That was the number of mounted bandits killed or captured in Northern Gaoyuan in that single day.

Seven battles broke out in seven different locations. After claiming seven victories, the army advanced without hesitation.

“After that, we killed or captured every mounted bandit we came across.”

Hundreds of crows wheeled through the sky, while perhaps ten times as many corpses lay scattered across the ground below.

By the time the Seven-Route Army’s horses finally came to a halt, five major mounted-bandit groups had been annihilated and more than ten others had surrendered.

“We had effectively achieved our objective by then.”

“I believe there’s more to the story.”

“Ah. You mean the nomads?”

“Exactly.”

Thanks to their swift, mobile strikes, the Seven-Route Army had suffered few casualties. But the successive battles had left them thoroughly exhausted.

That was when thousands of nomads appeared amid a massive cloud of dust.

“To be honest, even I felt dizzy when I saw them.”

There were thousands of them, and every single one was a master of mounted combat.

No matter how seasoned a Peak master Wipeng was, he had no way to turn the tide of battle alone.

“That was when the incident I reported earlier in my missive occurred.”

“You mean the ones who called themselves khans?”

The great nomadic empire that had once ruled even the Central Plains had long since faded into distant history. But the conquerors’ bloodline had not died out, and neither had the title of khan.

“There were two of them. They came forward first and introduced themselves…”

“Temur and Chinggen, descendants of the Great Khan and members of the Golden Clan.[1312]”

“Exactly.”

Wipeng nodded.

The young chieftains of the steppe had each arrived with two thousand riders. They were neither aggressive nor arrogant.

Instead, they cautiously attempted to converse in halting Korean.

“Is there anyone among you from the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

The battle everyone had expected never took place.

All because of the name of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

[1312] The Golden Clan is a traditional name for the ruling lineage descended from the khans.

“The rumor had already reached Gaoyuan. They knew about the relationship between Great Hero Jeok and the Third Young Master, and said they had no wish to become our enemies.”

“That is precisely what puzzles me. It seems rather suspicious that they would back down merely because of the Fire King’s reputation.”

“Ah, that? It didn’t sit right with me either, so I beat the truth out of the mounted-bandit prisoners.”

Wipeng grinned as he continued.

“They’d already been taught a harsh lesson last winter. Great Hero Jeok killed two notorious mounted-bandit leaders from Gaoyuan—Black Sand and the Human Butcher—with a single palm strike. Temur and Chinggen were both there.”

“They were frightened.”

“On the other hand, it benefited them as well. Once the leaders were dead, the mounted-bandit remnants fell into chaos. Temur and Chinggen absorbed them and grew as powerful as they are now.”

Temur and Chinggen had been lucky.

Black Sand and the Human Butcher had died in the same place, and not long afterward, even the Heavenly Wind Band had been annihilated by Jeok Cheongang. A power vacuum had formed.

After swallowing up the mounted-bandit remnants and gathering the scattered nomads, the two men had risen to become powers in Gaoyuan in the span of only a year.

“They said they wanted to remain on friendly terms from now on. They even loaded us down with furs and plundered gold and silver.”

“What? Ha-ha-ha!”

Jin Wikyung burst into delighted laughter.

The outcome could not have been better.

The campaign had further strengthened the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s fame and standing in the Shanxi Murim while also winning the support of its affiliated sects and the common people.

“You’ve worked hard. Much of the credit belongs to you.”

“I don’t know about that, but I do know my cup is empty.”

“Ha-ha! Then let’s drink until we’re both thoroughly drunk tonight.”

The two men traded cups and stories.

So much had happened over the past year that they had no shortage of things to discuss.

“Oh, right. What happened to the Seongun Escort Bureau?”

“We finished dealing with it completely right after you left. Though I suppose we should call it the Jin Family Escort Bureau now.”

Woo Hwangtae, chief of the Seongun Escort Bureau, had fled with his family, taking only a paltry sum with them. It had been discovered that they had bribed several officials and secretly diverted military supplies.

Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao, an ardent admirer of Jin Taekyung, had of course provided considerable help during the process.

“Our cooperation with the other sects is progressing smoothly as well. An escort caravan traveling through Mount Song to Hefei is already under way.”

“Mount Song and Hefei…?”

“Shaolin and Namgung. It was too good an offer to refuse.”

Shaolin, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim, and the Namgung Family, counted among the foremost of the Five Great Families.

Both were such enormous powers that Jin Wikyung would have been satisfied merely to establish trade with them. Instead, they had approached him first—and offered extremely generous terms at that.

“Great Hero Jeok’s presence has been a tremendous help to our family.”

Jin Wikyung merely smiled at Wipeng’s remark.

He firmly believed that in the Murim, at least, no favor came without a price.

Their goodwill contained the price of two people.

One was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

The other was the value of Jin Taekyung, a Sleeping Dragon.

Come to think of it, it’s already been a year since our youngest left.

It had been a year filled with countless hardships and events.

Once the ground thawed, the Star-Array Grand Banquet would be held in Henan. The brothers would meet again there.

Are you staying safe?

Jin Wikyung raised his cup, thinking of his thoughtless youngest brother, who had not contacted him even once. Just then, Wipeng spoke.

“By the way, what were you planning to paint this time?”

“I wonder.”

“You were grinding ink without even deciding what to paint?”

“It happens from time to time. I often spend one or two shichen[1313] grinding ink, only to put everything away again.”

“Huh. Are you truly trying to become a master painter now?”

“Put that thought aside for now. But once this painting is complete, I think I’d be happy to be called a master painter.”

“Didn’t you just say you hadn’t decided what to paint?”

[1313] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

“It’s merely that I can’t quite picture what it will look like. I decided on the title long ago.”

“Then what is this magnificent work called?”

Jin Wikyung answered with a smile.

“The Sleeping Dragon Enters Service.”

He was a young man in shabby clothes.

His long, loose hair reached his shoulder blades, and thick stubble covered his chin and upper lip.

The crowning touch was the iron balls dangling from all four limbs, making him look like a convict in a forced-labor camp.

Yet one thing about him was different.

His eyes.

The young man stared into the blue-white flame with a gaze of unfathomable depth, then muttered,

“Ah. This would be the perfect place to grill some meat.”

The next instant—

Fwoosh! Smack!

With a savage crack of displaced air, a wrinkled palm slammed into the back of the young man’s head.

“What an insolent brat! How dare you even think of grilling meat over our sect’s sacred flame!”

The old man was beside himself with rage, but the young man merely grumbled.

“Ah, why not? It should be fine if I just stick it in for a second and pull it right back out.”

“What did you say?”

“You’ve never heard of kiln-roasted pork belly? It’s insanely good.”

“You—you’re dead today!”

Smack! Crash!

On an early spring day, as the earth thawed and fresh shoots poked their heads aboveground, peaceful Mount Jiuhua began to grow noisy.

Chapter 237

Jeok Cheongang roared at the top of his lungs.

“You’re a disgrace to our sect!”

“No, I’m not.”

“What do you mean, you’re not? In all the hundreds of years of the Fire Gate Clan’s history, there has never been a bastard who wanted to grill meat over the sacred flame!”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“What?”

“I’m not an official Disciple yet. So I can’t be a disgrace to the Fire Gate Clan.”

“…!”

His face turned bright red, as though it might burst at any moment.

Before he could shout even louder, I quickly slung my pack over my shoulder.

“If there’s nothing else to pack, let’s get out of here.”

“Y-you little…”

Jeok Cheongang’s fist trembled, but after a moment, he let out a deep sigh.

This was hardly the first time something like this had happened over the past year. Even the famously short-tempered Fire King had reached the point where he simply took it in stride.

Ah, I’m so proud.

I had actually managed to beat the Fire King at something. Somehow, it felt like I had accomplished something incredible.

After glaring at my foolish grin, he turned toward the seventeen ancestral urns and bowed deeply.

“Your unworthy Disciple, Jeok Cheongang, will take his leave. Until then, please remain in good health.”

“Shouldn’t you wish them Buddhahood?”

“…And here, I swear that I will turn that bastard into a proper human being.”

Having firmly renewed his resolve before the seventeen former Sect Leaders, Jeok Cheongang rose to his feet.

“Come. Let’s go, you beast.”

“Wait a moment.”

I slowly looked around the enormous cavern.

This was where I had spent the past year. There had been times when the pain was enough to make me think I would die, and there had been happy moments too. Sometimes, I had been so sick of the place that I wanted to smash through the stone gate and run outside that very instant.

But when had it happened?

Little by little, everything had become familiar, and the happy days had begun to outnumber the painful ones.

Even the tremendous heat pouring from the blue-white flame now felt as warm and cozy as home.

“What are you thinking about so intently?”

“Just…”

What was I supposed to call this feeling?

After a moment’s thought, the words slipped out.

“I was thinking meat would taste really good grilled over that.”

“You little bastaaard!”

Dodging Jeok Cheongang as he flew into a rage, I placed my hand against the stone gate. As I channeled the internal energy from my dantian into it, the tightly sealed door slowly slid open.

SYSTEM

Scorching Sun Divine Arts internal energy detected.
You may freely enter and exit Fire Gate Cavern!

Take care.

Thanks for everything over the past year.

And…

Your unworthy Disciple, Jin Taekyung, will take his leave.

I raced out of the wide-open cavern like the wind. The iron balls dangling from my limbs whipped around like pinwheels.

Mount Jiuhua had been famous since ancient times for its spiritual energy.

With auspicious energy filling the entire mountain, it was only natural for spiritual herbs such as ginseng and He Shou Wu[1314] to grow there. To herbalists, the mountain was no different from a gold mine.

“Just you wait. Today, I’m finding one.”

At the foot of Mount Jiuhua, a middle-aged herbalist with the surname Hong pulled the strings of his straw sandals tight.

He had traveled all the way from Sichuan in hopes of striking it rich, only to spend more than fifteen days coming up empty-handed.

[1314] *He Shou Wu* is a plant used in traditional Chinese medicine, also known as fo-ti.

"Damn it. What happened to all the spiritual herbs? It's like every last one has vanished…"

The herbalists who had come with him had already given up and gone home. They had searched everywhere from the foot of Mount Jiuhua to halfway up the mountain without finding a single ginseng root.

There might have been a chance farther up, but something more terrifying than any wild beast lived there.

The Fire King.

Even martial artists who killed people as casually as they ate meals trembled at the mere mention of his name.

Hong had once heard that the Fire King had single-handedly torn apart and killed a thousand vicious fiends of the terrifying Demonic Cult.

When he had asked how such a thing was possible, he had been told that the Fire King was a three-headed, six-armed monster.

But they said it's safe as long as I don't go past the midpoint. Don't be scared, Hong. You have eight mouths to feed.

To cover the cost of coming this far, his wife had even been forced to sell the silver ring she had received as a wedding gift. How could he face her if he went home empty-handed?

Smack! Smack!

The herbalist slapped his cheeks to steel his resolve, then began climbing the mountain.

Less than two shichen later,[1315] he encountered the strangest sight he had ever seen.

"So what is samgyeopsal?"

"You don't know pork belly? Is it called something else here?"

"No, you impudent brat. Just where are you from that you keep going on about what things are called?"

"I'm from Korea! Do you know kimchi?"[1316]

"…You grow more insane by the day. Is there something wrong with your Fire Gate Divine Technique?"

A wild-haired freak and a tiny old man were walking down the mountain path, having an incomprehensible conversation.

The pair looked strange enough already, but as they drew closer, the herbalist heard a series of thunderous noises and his eyes widened.

Clank. Rattle. Boom! Rattle-rattle. Boom!

W-what in the world is that?

[1315] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are approximately four hours.

[1316] *Kimchi* is a Korean dish of fermented vegetables, often napa cabbage.

The source of the heavy noises was the iron balls chained to the freak's limbs.

The smaller ones were as large as a child's head, while the larger ones were big enough to fit inside a basket.

With dozens of such vicious objects dangling from his body, the herbalist had no choice but to be shocked.

What am I looking at?

The herbalist stared blankly at the sight, then suddenly jolted.

Two pairs of eyes had drawn close enough to stare directly into his face.

Up close, the freak had a thick beard, while the old man's face was covered in blotches and more wrinkles than he could count.

"Gyaaaah!"

As the herbalist nearly suffered a fit, the tiny old man addressed him.

"Hey."

"Y-yes?"

"Where are you headed?"

"I-I'm going to dig up medicinal herbs."

The herbalist barely managed to squeeze out the words.

He didn't know why, but instinct told him that something terrible would happen if he failed to answer.

The old man looked him up and down, then clicked his tongue.

"You've wasted your time. Don't put yourself through all that for nothing. Go home."

"W-wasted my time?"

Despite his terror, the herbalist instantly snapped to attention.

Go home? If he returned empty-handed now, he would have wasted nearly two months of his life.

With the heavy load on his shoulders, that was absolutely unacceptable.

This old man is no ordinary person.

It wasn't just his unusual appearance. Even his manner of speaking made it sound as though he could see through all the affairs of the world.

The thought flashed through the herbalist's mind like lightning, and he collapsed to his knees.

"Please help me just this once!"

"Good heavens, what's gotten into you? What could this old man possibly do to help?"

"No! You're the Mountain Spirit! You already know everything, don't you?"

Bafflement spread across the old man's face.

"…What spirit?"

"Mountain Spiriiit!"

The freak beside him clutched his stomach and burst out laughing.

"Puhahaha! He thinks you're a Mountain Spirit. Old Master, wasn't it three months ago that you forgot the formula while circulating your qi and nearly became a ghost?"

Wham! Craaack!

The freak was still roaring with laughter when a single punch from the old man sent him flying dozens of *jang*[1317] away, where he crashed into the ground.

The herbalist's faith only deepened.

The Mountain Spirit subdued the evil spirit!

It was only natural to trust the white-haired old man more than the ragged freak. The herbalist pleaded once more.

"Mountain Spirit! Please help me just this once!"

"Mountain Spirit, my ass. And there's nothing this old man can do for you. I already pulled them all up, so what do you expect me to do?"

"P-pulled them up? Who pulled up all the spiritual herbs on Mount Jiuhua?"

"Now you're finally making sense."

"W-who would do such a thing…?"

The old man clasped his hands behind his back and gazed toward the distant mountain.

"My, what fine weather."

"…"

"What are you staring at? Whoever pulls them up first gets to keep them."

Despair crossed the herbalist's face. Only then did he realize that the old man before him was no immortal.

"Then are you an herbalist too, Elder?"

"Hm? Well, I was for a few days. Digging up medicinal herbs is rather difficult."

"You tear people's heads off easily enough."

The evil spirit—or rather, the freak—had returned and casually joined the conversation while dusting off his clothes.

His manner and tone were so nonchalant that the massive trees snapped apart behind him might as well not have existed.

"My ancestors always said there was no point feeding spiritual herbs to a Disciple. They were absolutely right."

"Buuurp."

"You son of a—!"

[1317] A *jang* is a traditional length unit of approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

A dreadful pressure poured from the old man's clenched fist. At last, the herbalist realized what the two men were.

"M-m-martial artists!"

"Now that you understand, give up and go home. And be careful not to spread unnecessary rumors."

The freak also offered his advice with a serious expression.

"Whatever you do, don't go any farther up. They say a monster named Fire King Jeok Cheongang lives there. If he catches you, he'll chew you up, tear you apart, savor you, and enjoy you while you're still alive—then kill you."

"…!"

"…!"

It was horrifying even to imagine. The herbalist shuddered as he pictured his own gruesome death.

Judging by the old man's similar reaction, this Fire King Jeok Cheongang had to be exactly what Hong had heard: a three-headed, six-armed monster.

"Understood? Make sure you remember what I told you."

"Y-yes, I understand."

That was the only answer the herbalist could give.

Someone had already beaten him to the herbs, and the two men before him were martial artists. If he made a nuisance of himself, he might lose his head.

His shoulders sagged as he stepped aside to let them pass.

"Oh, wait. Sir, if this is good enough, would you like it?"

Swish.

The freak rummaged through his pack and suddenly held out a ginseng root about three finger joints long.

Startled by the unexpected kindness, the herbalist asked in a trembling voice,

"W-why are you giving this to me?"

"If you go home like this, you'll have nothing to show for it. Judging by your age, you probably have a family to support too. Where did you come from?"

"S-Sichuan Province."

"Sichuan Province is fun, isn't it? I used to play it all the time during evening self-study.[1318]"

"Pardon?"

"Never mind. Anyway, you came a long way, so use this to help cover your travel expenses."

The old man, who had been silently watching, clicked his tongue.

[1318] In Korean, "Sichuan Province" (*Sacheonseong*) is also the name of a tile-matching game.

"You little fool. You give him something worth only a few coins, then act like you've made some grand gesture. If a man is going to be generous, he should give generously."

"Come on, that's all I have left. What else am I supposed to do?"

"You call that ginseng? At least exchange it for silver."

"How?"

"People determine the value of an object."

"Oh. I hadn't thought of that."

What kind of bizarre conversation was this?

As the herbalist looked back and forth between them, feeling as though he had been bewitched, the freak suddenly shouted at the top of his lungs.

"Anyone want to buy some ginseng?"

It was still early dawn. As the cold wind blew, the trees shuddered.

Then several dozen men appeared on the mountain path below, marching in orderly rows.

Blue martial uniforms and sword sheaths hung from their waists. At a glance, it was obvious that every one of them was a highly trained martial artist.

"Guh!"

The herbalist's mouth fell open, but the other two remained perfectly calm. The freak gently waved the ginseng root worth three silver nyang.[1319]

"I'll sell it for a hundred silver nyang.[1320]"

What a highway robber.

The herbalist swallowed the words that had risen to his throat. Just then, the middle-aged man at the head of the group spoke.

"I'll buy it."

"…!"

The shocks were not over. The old man let out a long yawn and casually added,

"Three hundred silver nyang.[1321] You're the richest man in Anhui, so you can afford that much."

The middle-aged man bowed deeply.

"That is a small price to pay for offending the Fire King. I'll buy it."

The freak grinned.

"Then may I ask the winning bidder's name?"

"Namgung Ryong."

The middle-aged man raised his head. The authority possessed only by a leader flashed in his deep-set eyes.

[1319] A *silver nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency.
[1320] A *silver nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency.
[1321] A *silver nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency.

“I am the Family Head of the Namgung Family.”

Chapter 238

The Namgung Family.

It was one of the Five Great Families that ruled the Murim alongside the Nine Sects and One Gang.

Their blood relatives alone numbered over a hundred, and once the martial artists under their command were included, their numbers reached into the thousands.

Perhaps that was why the sheer scale of their estate put the Jin Family of Taiyuan to shame.

“Wow.”

How many times larger was it? Five times? Ten?

As if to demonstrate the family’s wealth and authority, the guest room we had been shown was both spacious and lavish.

Jeok Cheongang watched me gape in admiration as though I were pathetic.

“Is this your first time visiting the Namgung Family?”

“…Of course it is.”

“Ah, right.”

It wasn’t as though the Namgung Family were some neighborhood convenience store.

Normally, I would have made at least one more sarcastic remark, but not today.

I knew that Jeok Cheongang and the Namgung Family were not on particularly friendly terms.

All because that bastard Jopil left a pile of shit behind.

When a student did something wrong, the school called his parents.

The Namgung Family was indisputably a great power of the Murim and the hegemon of Anhui. They could hardly have avoided becoming entangled with Jeok Cheongang after he took as his Disciple a murderer who had brutally slain dozens of commoners within the province.

Then again, that’s probably why he came along without complaint.

Remembering something I had heard at an inn in Shanxi Province, I asked, “He was the Azure Sky Sword King, right? The person who came looking for you back then.”

“That’s right. He was the one who first informed me of what had happened, and he was also the one who later granted my request. I owe him a great debt.”

On the day Jeok Cheongang had been unable to bring himself to kill Jopil and let him go, if the Namgung Family had intervened, Jopil would never have made it out of Anhui alive.

The person Jeok Cheongang had gone to see at the time was the Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family, the Azure Sky Sword King.

"What kind of person is he?"

"I have only met him twice, but… the Sword King I know is truly a man obsessed with swords."

"Oh. A sword nut."

"A sword nut?"

"It means someone who's crazy about swords. It's a compliment, so let it go."

"There's no trusting anything you say."

Pretty sharp.

Jeok Cheongang gave me a suspicious glare, then continued.

"In any case, there is no doubt that he is an unpredictable man. He wanted a duel with this old man in exchange for sparing Jangcheon."

"A duel?"

"Can you guess what kind of man he is now?"

"Yeah, I'm getting a pretty clear picture."

A horrific series of murders had taken place in Anhui, yet the Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family—the hegemon of the province—had let the culprit go.

Setting aside the injustice suffered by the victims, it could not have been a welcome outcome for the Namgung Family either.

People would whisper that one of the Five Great Families was incompetent.

He really is a sword nut.

They said Supreme Peak masters trained endlessly for even the slightest scrap of enlightenment.

I had yet to meet the Azure Sky Sword King, but I suspected he was that kind of person.

That aside…

"Who won the duel?"

"The day after his duel with this old man, the Azure Sky Sword King entered seclusion."

"Oh."

"The difference was half a form."

In other words, Jeok Cheongang had won by the narrowest of margins.

Even fights between Third Rate martial artists could be decided by the smallest detail. What, then, of a battle between Supreme Peak masters? The outcome would be decided by a difference as thin as a single strand of silk.

"It happened more than twenty years ago, so he must be even stronger now. He was formidable even then, but I can no longer guarantee victory with any confidence."

I stared at Jeok Cheongang's solemn expression.

Even a man with such earth-shaking martial arts was only human.

I had realized that several times during the year we spent together in Fire Gate Cavern, and it had brought us closer.

The infirmities of old age.

A curse wrought by time that even a Supreme Peak master could not overcome.

Fortunately, a stroke of heavenly luck had eased his symptoms. But it had only slowed the wheel already in motion. It could not stop it completely.

Guessing how Jeok Cheongang felt, I put on my brightest expression.

“Come on, don’t worry too much. We didn’t come here to fight. We were simply invited to the Sword King’s birthday celebration.”

“Do you truly think that?”

“Hm?”

“Didn’t this old man tell you? He is obsessed with swords.”

“…!”

A thought flashed through my mind.

People obsessed with something paid no attention to the world around them. They immersed themselves in it—literally, *madly*—solely to satisfy their desires.

Alcohol, gambling, drugs… martial arts were no different.

It had been none other than the Azure Sky Sword King who released Jopil so that he could spar with Jeok Cheongang.

“Now that I think about it, the timing is awfully convenient.”

“He must have been waiting.”

“So his birthday is just an excuse?”

“The Azure Sky Sword King is the sort of man who could change his birthday hundreds of times. I suspect the only day that truly matters to him is the day he draws his last breath. That is when he will have no choice but to put down his sword.”

“…”

What the hell? That was terrifying.

The bastard wasn’t just a sword nut. He was completely insane.

I was rubbing the goose bumps from my arms when a delicate woman’s voice came from outside the door.

“The Family Head wishes to meet Young Hero Jin.”

Clank, boom. Clank, boom.

The chains clashed, and the iron balls gouged deep into the ground, leaving long tracks behind them.

I glanced back and saw that the entire route I had taken was marked by a line.

Is this Hansel and Gretel?

If the siblings in the fairy tale had possessed something like this, they would never have gotten lost.

Even if they had, there would have been no need to worry. I imagined Hansel strangling the witch with a Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron chain while Gretel smashed her in the back of the head with an iron ball, then shook my head.

"Ugh, no. That's not it."

"Young Hero Jin?"

The maid was looking at me as though I were insane. I waved my hand.

"No, it's nothing. Let's keep going."

"No, that's not what I meant…"

"Yes?"

"I-I beg your pardon, but those things you have with you are rather…"

"Ah."

The maid was pointing at my iron balls.

Apparently, I had done quite a number on someone else's courtyard.

Several sturdy servants had gathered by then, filling in the marks I had left with dirt while wearing gloomy expressions.

"I'm sorry. I'll just carry them, then."

Clank.

I gathered the chains together and lifted the iron balls.

I had weighed them faithfully during the first few months, but after that, I gave up. Whenever they got heavier, I simply assumed more weight had been added and left it at that.

They must weigh a hell of a lot by now.

In any case, there was no way I could cross the grounds of the Namgung Family like that without attracting attention.

To everyone else, I probably looked like a fruit seller hauling several dozen watermelons.

Every step brought more murmurs to my ears.

"Who is that guy? Have you heard anything?"

"No idea. With those iron balls chained to him, he looks like a prisoner."

"Can you really say he's chained to them?"

"…I suppose not."

"No one could possibly carry that many iron balls of that size. They must be weapons plated with iron."

"What on earth is he? Judging by his appearance, he's a beggar among beggars. At that level, he'd be an Elder even in the Beggars' Sect."

"He doesn't have any knots,[1322] so I don't think that's it…"

As I listened to the Namgung martial artists quietly debate among themselves, one thought crossed my mind.

You fucking bastards.

A beggar among beggars? An Elder of the Beggars' Sect?

That year in Fire Gate Cavern had been a literal hell of scorching heat.

If a sauna was dangerous to pregnant women and the elderly, Fire Gate Cavern was simply dangerous to human beings.

My sweat had formed puddles, and every breath had felt as though my lungs were burning away.

I'd even deliberately endured it without using Logout.

After going so long without washing, the habit had become so ingrained that I could no longer tell whether I smelled or whether insects were crawling over my body.

I should've washed as soon as we arrived.

If we had gone to the inn first, I could have soaked in hot water, but everything had gone wrong when we came straight to the Namgung Family.

Jeok Cheongang had been speaking so seriously about the Azure Sky Sword King. I couldn't exactly have told him I was going to scrub off some grime first.

"You bastards try it yourselves… It's not like you're going to scrub my back."

The maid's steps quickened after I muttered that. It was definitely my imagination.

A short while later, I arrived at a pavilion surrounded by tight security.

The Namgung Family's guards, each with the two characters for Azure Heaven embroidered across his chest, blocked my path.

"Are you Young Hero Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

I concealed my surprise and nodded.

There were ten guards. They ranged in age from their twenties to their forties, and every last one of them was a Peak master.

Good heavens. They were using ten Peak masters merely to guard a pavilion.

Is this why they're counted among the Five Great Families?

For the first time, I could truly feel the power and status of the Namgung Family.

Perhaps he noticed my reaction, because the youngest-looking guard let out a quiet laugh.

"Disarm yourself."

I suppressed my surprise and answered, "Disarm myself? I don't have any weapons on me."

"Then what do you call the things in your hands?"

[1322] In wuxia fiction, knots on a Beggars' Sect member's bags can indicate rank.

“Oh.”

Right. I had these.

If even a ballpoint pen could kill someone, the iron balls I was carrying certainly qualified as weapons.

To me, they were merely heavy clothes I had to wear, but other people saw them differently.

The problem was…

“I’m sorry, but I’m still training. I can’t just take them off whenever I want.”

“Training?”

“Yes.”

It wasn’t a lie. I had grown so accustomed to them that I saw no particular reason to remove the iron balls.

But the young guard looked thoroughly displeased.

“It can’t be helped. Rules are rules.”

“Well, then I can’t help it either.”

Clank.

I deliberately raised my hands and feet one after another.

Shackles were fastened tightly around all four limbs, and unusually gleaming chains connected them to the iron balls.

“These can’t be removed without a key.”

“Who has the key?”

“Of course, the Ol—no, my Master has it.”

“Your Master would be…”

A year had passed since Jeok Cheongang had publicly declared me his Disciple.

Even a servant would know that much. There was no way a Peak master could be unaware of it.

No matter how vast the continent was, the Fire King Jeok Cheongang was one of only a handful of Supreme Peak masters under heaven, and his every move attracted attention.

“Hmm.”

The young guard furrowed his brow as he looked back and forth between me and the iron balls. Then he abruptly said, “We’ll have to cut them off.”

“What?”

No, what the hell had he just said?

Even when I gave him an incredulous look, the young guard remained perfectly confident.

“The Namgung Family has its own rules. Great Hero Jeok will understand.”

“…Uh, I don’t think he will.”

Something Jeok Cheongang had always said in Fire Gate Cavern suddenly came to mind.

“This old man entered the Fire Gate Clan at the age of nine. Say a hundred people began learning martial arts at that age… This old man is the only one who grew as strong as I am now. So how do you think I came this far?”

“How?”

“I shoved aside bastards from the unorthodox factions, sent dark-path figures packing, and killed every bastard who set fires like a Demonic Cultist. In that spirit, add a hundred geun[1323] to the iron balls.”

It was a history written in blood and violence.

Even the Roaring Fury Swordsman, the Senior Brother of the Zhongnan Sect’s Sect Leader, had been beaten black and blue. I could only imagine what would happen to this young guard.

I offered him my most sincere advice.

“Do that and you’ll die. Seriously, you’ll be in real trouble.”

“…What did you say?”

“I mean, you won’t die by my hand.”

“How dare you—!”

The young guard shouted angrily and placed his hand on his sword hilt.

That was when a deep, resonant voice infused with internal energy reached everyone’s ears.

“Enough. Let him in.”

It was Namgung Ryong, Family Head of the Namgung Family.

[1323] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). A hundred geun is 60 kg (about 132 lb).

Chapter 239

Namgung Ryong was a sharp-featured middle-aged man.

As befitted the Family Head of the venerable martial household known as the Namgung Family, his dignified bearing radiated authority. His lips were pressed into a firm line, revealing something of his stern disposition.

In fact, despite traveling with him all the way from Mount Jiuhua to Hefei, I had heard him say fewer than ten words.

“Would you wait a moment? I have one important matter left to attend to.”

As the Family Head of the Namgung Family, he must have had a considerable workload.

I was used to that from watching Jin Wikyung, so I nodded without complaint.

“Ah, yes.”

Crunch!

Oh, right. I forgot about the iron balls.

The chair had shattered beneath me, unable to bear their weight. Still sitting amid the wreckage, I glanced at Namgung Ryong.

“Oops, what happened here? You should make your chairs a little sturdier…”

“It was made of ebony imported from Nanman.[1324] The wood is harder than steel.”

“…”

“Just stand.”

A short while later, Namgung Ryong set down the bamboo slips he had been carefully examining and spoke.

“I invited you here as a guest, yet I have treated you poorly. You have my apology.”

“No, it’s fine. You may have been busy.”

“I also owe you an apology for my son’s discourtesy.”

“What do you mean…?”

“I believe I heard some commotion.”

I suddenly remembered the young guard who had aggressively demanded that I disarm myself.

I wondered why the youngest one was acting so cocky…

“He’s your son?”

“He’s my only child, so I doted on him. Perhaps because of that, he still has many shortcomings.”

Yeah, he definitely has shortcomings.

Thinking of the bastard’s sour expression, I nodded.

[1324] Nanman is a historical Chinese term—often translated as “Southern Barbarians”—for peoples and territories south of the traditional Chinese heartland.

“It’s all right. I’m sure he’ll improve with time.”

“…”

“Was there something else you wanted to say?”

“Ahem. No, nothing.”

Namgung Ryong cleared his throat and continued.

“People around him kept filling his head with talk of his talent for martial arts. You’ve heard the title Sword Dragon, haven’t you?”

“The Sword Dragon?”

“So you have heard of him. Well, it would be impossible not to…”

“I’ve never heard of him before.”

“Oh.”

“That’s a cool title, though.”

“Is it…?”

A dark shadow passed over Namgung Ryong’s face.

“He is well known throughout the martial world as one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

“Oh, so he’s one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes. My second elder brother is one of them too.”

“I heard the two of them got into quite a fight as soon as they entered Heaven’s Gate Temple.”

“Good grief. They were young—very young. If they had just enrolled, they would’ve been twenty. That’s the age when people act like that.”

“…”

“It’s all right. People that age grow up by beating each other black and blue. But why did you call me here…?”

This man was definitely more of a doting fool than he looked.

Momentarily at a loss after my swift interruption, Namgung Ryong finally spoke.

“It concerns Great Hero Jeok.”

“That old—no, my Master?”

“That’s right.”

He nodded gravely before continuing.

“I’ll be direct. I want you to dissuade Great Hero Jeok.”

My relaxed posture stiffened on its own. I ran a hand over the beard that had grown thick over the past year and asked,

“Is this about his duel with the Azure Sky Sword King… Great Hero Namgung Cheon?”

“That’s right. Do you know what happened between Great Hero Jeok and my father more than twenty years ago?”

"I know roughly what happened. I also know that my Master won."

"It was by the narrowest of margins. The battle was balanced on a knife's edge. Either of them could have won."

Namgung Ryong sighed.

"My father must have been deeply resentful of that defeat. For several years afterward, he devoted himself to secluded training, stewing over it."

Defeat always cut deep.

And if the person in question was one of the greatest masters in the world—someone who loved martial arts enough to be called sword-crazed—the sense of loss would only be that much greater.

If his own son is talking about it like this, he must've been really pissed.

This would be a fight between Supreme Peak masters. Its intensity went without saying, and if things went too far, blood could easily be spilled.

If they had planned to calmly exchange a few moves, laugh good-naturedly, and withdraw, Namgung Ryong would have had no reason to bring this up.

The problem was…

"I'm not confident I can persuade my Master, either. No, I can't persuade him."

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was not the sort of man who would back down merely because someone tried to stop him.

The year I had spent in Fire Gate Cavern had taught me many things. Not only about martial arts, but also about the man beside me.

Jeok Cheongang was not a difficult man to read.

"He'd rather die than back down."

"You misunderstand me. I'm not saying you should do your best to stop them. I'm saying you must stop them."

Namgung Ryong stared at me.

"Do you know what will happen if something happens to either of them during this duel?"

"I can make a rough guess."

The Fire King and the Sword King. Both were giants who ruled over the martial world.

If the worst happened, the aftermath would be like a meteor crashing into the shore of a quiet lake.

"Then you shouldn't have brought us to the Namgung Family."

"That…"

"I know. You had no choice. But if even the Family Head can't persuade his father, what could I possibly do?"

I shook my head. Whatever else I said here would be pointless.

"I'll at least try talking to him."

“I’ll do my best as well. I should go see my father immediately.”

“I’m not sure that’ll do you any good…”

“What do you mean?”

“Nothing. Then I’ll be going.”

I gave the puzzled Namgung Ryong a polite bow and turned away.

As soon as I left the pavilion, I found the young guard—or rather, the Lesser Family Head of the Namgung Family, Sword Dragon Namgung Ok—waiting for me with his eyes blazing.

“You bastard!”

“Oh, what now? We’ve never even met before, so why do you keep calling me a bastard?”

“I heard everything from outside. How dare you treat my father with such disrespect? Do you think the great Namgung Family is a joke?”

“What disrespect? I showed him the utmost courtesy, just as I do my Master.”

“What kind of bullshit are you spouting?”

“I’m serious. If you’re that curious, ask my Master. Anyway, I’m leaving.”

I was about to drag the iron balls past Namgung Ok when—

“How dare you!”

Shing! Click!

It happened in an instant.

The blade, radiating a chilling sharpness, had not even been drawn halfway before it disappeared back into its scabbard.

Namgung Ok stared at my hand pressing down on his sword hilt.

“H-how did you…?”

“That isn’t something you should draw and swing around so casually. Keep doing that and you’ll get yourself killed.”

“…!”

“Act like a gentleman, young man.”

Pat, pat.

I patted the shoulder of the man who had gone rigid as a stone statue, then approached the wide-eyed maidservant.

“Excuse me.”

“Y-yes?”

“Is there a mountain nearby where not many people go?”

“Why would you want to…?”

“No particular reason.”

I glanced at the clear sky and continued.

“I thought I’d get some air.”

I shook off the maidservant, who insisted on accompanying me, and began climbing the mountain path.

It was the height of spring. The mountain was green, and the sky was blue.

I walked past drifting scraps of cloud and birds chattering from the branches. After some time, I entered a broad clearing and suddenly stopped.

“You can come out now.”

Nothing changed. Leaves rippled in the breeze, sparrows chirped as they ceaselessly turned their heads, and unknown wildflowers stood in full bloom.

Yet an incongruous presence towered amid the natural scenery.

Then a voice wormed its way into my ears.

“Not bad. Not bad at all.”

He was a remarkably tall old man. The fingers stroking the beard that reached his chest were knobby, and a fierce light shone from the eyes set deep in their sockets.

I clasped my hands before the old man, who looked remarkably similar to Namgung Ryong.

“It is an honor to meet the Azure Sky Sword King, Great Hero Namgung Cheon.”

The Azure Sky Sword King Namgung Cheon—the Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family and one of the Ten Kings—studied me before abruptly speaking.

“You must have had a reason for calling this old man all the way out here.”

“What do you mean…?”

“Great Hero Jeok took a sly little bastard as his Disciple in his later years. I know exactly what you’re scheming, so there’s no need to play dumb.”

“Ah, I’m sorry if I offended you.”

I scratched the back of my head and grinned. It was embarrassing to have him cut straight to the point, but it also made things easier.

“Did I make it a little… too obvious?”

I had first noticed his presence in the Family Head’s Hall.

Namgung Ryong had failed to sense him, but I had not. The Azure Sky Sword King was the reason I had come up the mountain under the pretense of getting some fresh air.

An unspoken invitation and acceptance had passed between us.

“Hah.”

A breathy sound escaped the Azure Sky Sword King’s lips. His expression seemed to ask what sort of brat he was dealing with.

“You’re an audacious one. Or perhaps you simply have no fear?”

“My Master says I’m just arrogant.”

“Yes, I believe that is the right word. Arrogant… It has been so long since anyone struck me that way that I had forgotten the feeling.”

“Of course. Who would dare act arrogantly toward the Azure Sky Sword King?”

“No one has for decades. Not until you appeared today.”

His fierce eyes fixed on me. That alone made my body hair stand on end and drew every sense taut.

“Speak. Why did you call this old man here?”

I took a deep breath. Then, without hesitation, I dropped to the ground and prostrated myself before the Azure Sky Sword King.

Clatter!

The chains collided, spewing a cacophonous rattle.

“What are you doing?”

“Please reconsider your duel with my Master.”

“Reconsider? Why should this old man do that?”

“I cannot tell you the reason.”

“…What?”

I had no idea what expression the Azure Sky Sword King was making.

But judging by the prickling at the back of my head, as if a blade were stabbing into it, he was clearly debating whether to kill me.

It does sound insane.

He had spent twenty years training for today’s duel.

And now some young brat who looked young enough to be his grandson had suddenly appeared and asked him to cancel it. On top of that, I was telling him I could not explain why.

But the die had already been cast. Pressing my face into the fresh earth, I spoke again.

“I’m sorry. But I cannot tell you the reason.”

“Tell me.”

“I cannot tell you.”

“You bastard!”

Whoooosh!

A tremendous wave of qi swept through the surroundings. Trees snapped, and flowers that had only just borne fruit were ripped out by the roots.

“This is the last time I’ll ask.”

My answer was already decided.

“I cannot tell you.”

As I repeated the same answer like a parrot, tangible killing intent pressed down on my entire body.

After a brief silence, the Azure Sky Sword King spoke.

“Get up.”

Crumble.

Clumps of dirt fell from me as I rose. The Azure Sky Sword King’s voice was as dry as desert sand.

“I waited twenty years.”

“Then please wait one more year.”

I continued calmly.

“I cannot tell you the exact reason, but my Master is not in good condition right now. You didn’t wait twenty years just to claim a victory like that, did you?”

“A victory like that…?”

The Azure Sky Sword King muttered the words under his breath and let out a hollow laugh.

“Great Hero Jeok trained his Disciple well.”

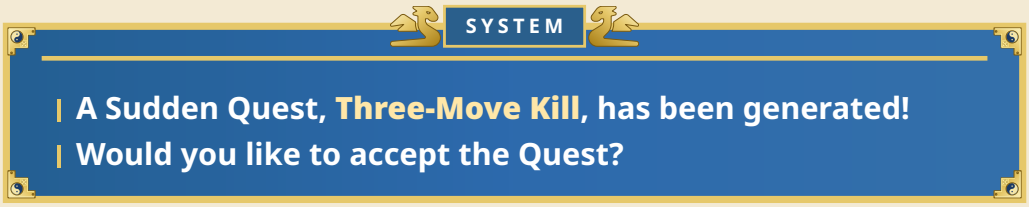
“He’ll be glad to hear that.”

“But you have the look of someone destined to die young. To survive in the martial world, one must possess at least a minimum of courtesy.”

“Are you saying…?”

“Three moves. If you can withstand three moves from this old man, I will grant your request.”

Ding.



I looked into his eyes, which boiled like lava.

These were three moves from none other than the Azure Sky Sword King. Three strikes capable of cleaving mountains and splitting rivers would rain down upon me.

I opened my parched lips.

“I’ll do it.”

Ding.

As the System notification announced that the Quest had been accepted, anger flared in the Azure Sky Sword King’s eyes.

“Your recklessness will be the death of you.”

“Maybe. Maybe not. But before that…”

I grinned and raised my arms.

Clank.

Dozens of iron balls swayed with the chains.

“May I take these off?”

“Go ahead. The outcome will not change.”

As the old man stared at me with cold, unyielding eyes, the majesty of an emperor who could force all under heaven to kneel surged from his entire body.

The blue sky overhead began to churn.

“Emperor’s Sword Form. Can you stop it?”

Craaack! Clang!

I tore apart the steel shackles that had bound my limbs for more than a year as easily as sheets of paper.

The instant the chains and iron balls fell to the ground—

Whoosh!

A flash of light burst from the Azure Sky Sword King’s waist.

Chapter 240

Smoke streamed from the old man's seven orifices.[1325]

It was Scorching Yang Qi, so dense it was visible to the naked eye, endlessly coiling around his small frame as it circulated through him.

And then, soon after—

Sssssss.

Five rings rose one after another above the crown of the cross-legged old man.

Some were blue and red, others black and white.

When the final yellow ring took shape, the five vivid rings, one in each of the five directional colors, were complete.

Five Qi Returning to Origin.

Jeok Cheongang, the small-framed old man who had just displayed the dream realm sought by every martial artist in Murim, suddenly opened his eyes.

"Come in."

The door opened the moment the words left his mouth.

A young man dressed in rags strode inside as though he owned the place and looked around.

"Weren't you circulating your qi?"

"Some bastard kept pacing outside the door. How was this old man supposed to concentrate with him distracting me?"

"Fair point. Ah, I should've just come in and watched the Olympics."

"It wasn't the Olympics or whatever you called it. It was Five Qi Returning to Origin."

"What does it matter? As long as you got the meaning across."

Jeok Cheongang silently regarded the young man, Jin Taekyung.

"Where have you been?"

"You know where. I went to see Great Hero Namgung Ryong, the Family Head."

"Family Head Namgung. Right. You did."

After muttering under his breath, Jeok Cheongang asked, "What did he say?"

"Oh, that."

Jin Taekyung stretched before continuing.

"The banquet's been canceled."

"The banquet was canceled? What does that mean?"

"Well, apparently the Azure Sky Sword King entered seclusion."

"Seclusion?"

[1325] The seven orifices are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

"They say he suddenly gained some minor insight or something. Anyway, that's how it turned out."

"Enlightenment…"

Jeok Cheongang gave a small nod.

"That's quite a coincidence."

Jin Taekyung stopped twisting his overgrown beard around one finger.

"What is?"

"The Azure Sky Sword King waited more than twenty years for today. Yet of all days, this happened today. How could it not be a coincidence?"

"…Maybe he got a little nervous when it was finally time to fight you?"

"Who knows?"

"Come on, it's obvious. Don't you think you're overthinking it?"

"You think so?"

"Yes. Absolutely."

Jeok Cheongang stared in silence as Jin Taekyung nodded vigorously.

"W-why?"

"Nothing."

"There's no such thing as 'nothing'!"

"Do I need your permission just to look at your face?"

"Have you never heard of image rights?"

"No. Shut your mouth before I use Flying Over Grass[1326] to stomp on your head."

"Yes, sir."

But the silence did not last long. Jin Taekyung glanced at the old man, gauging his mood, then spoke again.

"Old Master."

"What?"

"This whole thing worked out okay, right?"

"There is nothing to call 'working out.' The date has merely been postponed for a little while."

"But we bought some time."

"Did you think this old man would lose?"

Jin Taekyung hurriedly waved his hands.

"That's not what I meant. Given the situation, even if you won, it wouldn't really count as a victory."

Even if I won, it wouldn't really count as a victory…

Jeok Cheongang repeated the words silently.

[1326] Flying Over Grass is a lightness-skill feat of crossing grass without touching the ground.

They were true. Had the duel taken place, he would have paid a heavy price regardless of the outcome.

The Azure Sky Sword King was an opponent he would have to face with everything he had.

If Jeok Cheongang suffered an Internal Injury in a fierce duel against him, the essence, qi, and spirit he had barely managed to bring into balance would collapse.

“Old Master?”

Jeok Cheongang raised his head from his thoughts. Jin Taekyung was looking at him with concern.

“Why did you call me?”

“No reason. Do I need permission even to call you once?”

“What a tiresome brat.”

Normally, Jeok Cheongang would have rapped him on the head, but today, he decided to let it slide.

He let out a quiet chuckle and rose from his seat.

“Let’s go.”

“Where?”

“Henan.”

The Star-Array Grand Banquet.

Even now, the most renowned masters of Murim would be gathering in Henan one after another.

Having let all four seasons pass them by, the two of them had taken quite a detour.

“The Namgung Family has no reason to keep us here, and we have no reason to remain. Leaving is only natural.”

“Leaving sounds good, but can’t we soak in some hot water first? I’ve got so much dirt caked onto me that my body feels heavy.”

“You should have brought that up much earlier, you brat. Don’t start pretending to care about cleanliness now. Go get us some travel money. We may be uninvited guests, but they should at least give us that much.”

“Wow. Now you’re even telling me to shake people down.”

“Why, you—!”

“I’m going. I’m going.”

Jin Taekyung grumbled as he left the pavilion.

He did not know that Jeok Cheongang was silently watching him.

Watching the shackles that had been hastily forced shut by sheer strength.

Watching the cleanly severed ends of his sleeves.

The old man watched until the young man’s back had receded into the distance, then muttered,

"…That brat. Going and doing something I never told him to."

His seasoned gray eyes swept toward a small mountain in the distance.

A faint cloud of dust was dispersing above the ridge covered in blue-green light.

The bright sun slipped behind the mountain, and darkness descended.

The Azure Sky Sword King, Namgung Cheon, stood motionless as the mountain wind whispered through the trees. Then he abruptly spoke.

"Who was that boy?"

Namgung Ryong, the Family Head of the Namgung Family, was standing quietly behind the Azure Sky Sword King. He answered,

"His name is Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Shanxi."

"The Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"Yes."

"So a Hidden Dragon was crouching in the borderlands."

"And the Fire King took that very Hidden Dragon under his wing."

"You're wrong."

The Azure Sky Sword King shook his head.

"The Fire King is the dragon pearl.[1327] It wasn't that he took the Hidden Dragon into his embrace. He became the dragon pearl himself."

"…!"

Namgung Ryong could not hide his astonishment. Though father and son had never been close, he knew what kind of man his father was.

One of the things he knew was that his father was a man of few words who was exceedingly stingy with his judgments of others.

Yet the words *Hidden Dragon* had come from his lips.

He had even said that the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, whose name shook all under heaven, had become the dragon pearl himself.

The man who never once praised even his own grandson…

A pang of hurt mingled with Namgung Ryong's curiosity.

"Is he truly that extraordinary?"

The Azure Sky Sword King did not answer the cautious question. Instead, he abruptly asked one of his own.

"How far have you mastered the Emperor's Sword Form?"

"…I have yet to break through the barrier of three-tenths mastery."

"When I was your age, I had mastered seven-tenths of the Emperor's Sword Form. I believe that was around the time the world began calling me the Sword King."

[1327] In Chinese lore, a dragon pearl is a precious orb associated with dragons.

“I apologize.”

Shame filled Namgung Ryong’s reply, but the Azure Sky Sword King paid it no mind.

He had not said it to rebuke his son, who was already sixty years old.

“More than twenty years ago, when my mastery of martial arts reached eight-tenths, a question suddenly occurred to me. I wanted to test my sword.”

“…”

Namgung Ryong silently lowered his head. He knew well what had happened afterward.

The clash between the Fire King and the Sword King.

The winner of that earth-shaking battle between two Supreme Peak masters had been the Fire King.

“During my secluded training, I faced countless towering walls. I struck and hammered at them without end, until at last, one of those walls collapsed.”

“Then…!”

“I have only just broken through a single wall. I have not yet achieved Great Completion.”

“Congratulations!”

Namgung Ryong performed a full bow before his father, trembling with excitement.

The Emperor’s Sword Form was the beginning and end of the dozens of secret arts possessed by the Namgung Family.

In the family’s entire history, only the founding Family Head had ever achieved Great Completion of the Emperor’s Sword Form.

True to his greatness as a martial artist, the Azure Sky Sword King had become the first in roughly a century to reach nine-tenths mastery of the Emperor’s Sword Form.

“Congratulations, is it?”

But the Azure Sky Sword King’s expression remained calm. No—he even looked hollow.

“Then let me ask you one thing. Can you withstand three moves of the Emperor’s Sword Form this old man unleashes?”

“How could I possibly dare… Surely?”

The Azure Sky Sword King quietly nodded.

Namgung Ryong’s eyes widened like lanterns.

It was unthinkable—something that neither should nor could have happened.

Yet his father had confirmed it.

That young man had withstood the Emperor’s Sword Form wielded by none other than the Azure Sky Sword King himself.

Even Namgung Ryong, who rarely lost his composure, spoke with a trembling voice.

"B-but he is only twenty-two."

"Yes, twenty-two. He possesses the Heavenly Martial Physique and has the Fire King Jeok Cheongang as his Master."

The Azure Sky Sword King raised his head and stared into the dark night sky.

For many long years, from the moment he first entered the world, he had lived under the name Namgung. He had carried the two characters *Azure Sky* in his heart and learned a sword that resembled the azure heavens.

But today, he had met a dragon soaring into the sky.

I thought one move would be enough.

He had put two-tenths of his power behind his sword, intending to teach the young man some manners.

Then three-tenths.

Then six-tenths.

And yet…

"Three moves. That's it, right? Thanks for going easy on me."

The young man had slung the iron balls over his shoulder and left.

All that remained in his wake were hundreds of trees and boulders carved apart by stroke after stroke, along with the mournful cries of birds that had suddenly lost their homes.

A Hidden Dragon. A Hidden Dragon.

The Azure Sky Sword King repeated those words in his mind, then spoke.

"Have they left?"

Namgung Ryong, who had only just gathered his wits, answered, "Yes. They left five shichen[1328] ago."

"Where did they say they were going?"

"Henan. They said they would attend the Star-Array Grand Banquet being held there in one month."

"The Star-Array Grand Banquet?"

The Azure Sky Sword King let out a hollow laugh.

"Make it clear to your son that he is not to show his face at this Star-Array Grand Banquet."

[1328] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; five shichen is about ten hours.

Black Mountain Stronghold was a bandit organization based along one of the major routes connecting Henan and Anhui.

Its leader, Heuk Jongpil, was an illiterate former butcher, but he was also a natural-born plunderer and a master who had honed his axe techniques to the Peak realm.

Thanks to that, he commanded more than three hundred underlings and lorded over them like a king.

Not that the Green Forest Alliance didn't bleed me dry.

No matter how capable Heuk Jongpil was, he was no match for the Green Forest Alliance.

The only reason he had managed to build Black Mountain Stronghold into what it was today was that he paid four-tenths of his monthly profits to the Green Forest Alliance in exchange for various forms of assistance.

For instance, the valuable intelligence delivered by the subordinate who had just entered.

"Boss, a letter arrived from the Green Forest Alliance headquarters! Here—"

Whack!

"You bastard! Don't you know we're all illiterate? Read it aloud!"

"It has information about the goods the Geumwa Merchant Group is transporting and the route they're taking. They say it should arrive within two days."

"What are you waiting for?"

"Yes?"

"Call everyone!"

The Star-Array Grand Banquet was an important event for martial artists and bandits alike.

Heuk Jongpil gathered all three hundred of his underlings and set up an ambush along the route the Geumwa Merchant Group would take.

Just one big haul. Let us land one.

If they managed to get their hands on even a single top-grade cat's-eye stone, they would still have a fortune left over after paying tribute to the Green Forest Alliance.

Feeding and arming more than three hundred able-bodied men was no small task.

"They should be here by now… Why haven't the scouts come back?"

"Who knows? We sent them out a shichen[1329] ago, but there hasn't been any word."

"Ugh. Trying to run a bandit operation with idiots like these is hard on the body. Hard on the body."

[1329] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; five shichen is about ten hours.

The next instant, Heuk Jongpil froze mid-grumble.

With a trembling hand, he pointed toward something approaching through the darkness at incredible speed.

"…Hey. What is that?"

"I-I'm not sure either."

Whoooosh!

Two silhouettes—one large and one small.

A long trail of red qi lingered behind them like the tail of a meteor shower.

Are they ghosts?

Heuk Jongpil was crouching in the grass, watching the sight, when it happened.

The two silhouettes racing along the mountain road at an unbelievable speed abruptly stopped.

A moment later, low voices drifted over.

"Why stick your nose into this?"

"It bugs me. They seem to be with those two who were skulking around earlier."

"We're going to be late at this rate, you brat."

"No matter how late we are, whoever sees the trash first should clean it up."

"Where did you learn to talk back every single time this old man says something?"

"Bastards like that always set fire to mountains."

"You little shit! Go break all four of their limbs."

"Yes, sir."

Heuk Jongpil had been listening intently to their conversation.

His eyes flew wide.

"W-we're fucking screwed! Everybody—!"

But his cry went no further.

Whoosh!

A brief rush of wind.

Then someone's enormous hand settled companionably around his shoulder.

"Everybody, what?"

Chapter 241

The Star-Array Grand Banquet.

With the most renowned masters in the world gathering in one place to pit their martial arts against one another, the name could not have been more fitting: a banquet of stars.

An old man with deep wrinkles around his eyes packed tobacco into a long-stemmed tobacco pipe as he spoke.

“It could also be called a festival of victory.”

They were in a large inn in southern Henan Province.

From among the people crowding around the old man, someone asked, “Why is that?”

“Why else? If the Central Plains Murim had lost, would there have been a Star-Array Grand Banquet? The Demonic Cult would have ruled the world by now, and they would be holding the Demonic Grand Banquet instead.”

“Ah, that is true.”

“But because we won, the Star-Array Grand Banquet can be held, and the great sects from across the world can gather in one place to renew their shared resolve. Speaking of which…”

The old man fumbled inside his robes, then waved his pipe.

“Does anyone have a light?”

The middle-aged man beside him quickly pulled out a flint and lit it for him.

Crack, crackle! Ssssss.

As the dry tobacco burned, the old man puffed on the stem. After blowing out several streams of smoke, he leaned back leisurely in his chair.

“If there is anything you’re curious about, ask away. This old man will tell you everything he knows.”

The people watching him with shining eyes began raising their hands all at once.

“Me! May I ask first?”

“Great Hero Song, then perhaps…”

“Hey, didn’t you hear me say I was going first?”

“I didn’t hear shit, you unorthodox-faction bastard!”

Wham! Crash!

Fists flew in an instant, and a table broke apart. The onlookers cheered at the sudden fight.

The guests who had kept their distance from the start shook their heads.

“Tsk, tsk. Martial artists.”

“Just let them be. It’s not as if this is the first time we’ve seen it.”

"That's the problem. There's never a quiet moment. With the Star-Array Grand Banquet right around the corner, every kind of bastard is flocking to Henan."

"Our trading run is over anyway. We might as well watch the show and enjoy the benefits."

The two merchants continued chatting quietly.

Dressed in fine blue silk robes, they were passing cups of liquor between them when a voice suddenly cut in.

"Is that Yeoahong[1330]?"

"Hm?"

The merchants stared at the owner of the voice in bewilderment.

A young man had somehow approached their table without either of them noticing. His nostrils flared as he stared intently at the cups in their hands.

"Isn't that Yeoahong? It looks like it…"

"It—it is. Yeoahong."

"I knew it."

As though he had achieved some great enlightenment, the young man slapped his knee and dragged over an empty chair.

"But the color looks a little weak. How much did you pay for this bottle?"

His movements were so smooth and natural that the merchants could only stare blankly at each other.

"H-how much was it?"

"T-two silver nyang."

The young man sighed.

"What a shame."

"What do you mean, a shame?"

"This has been mixed with water. Can't you tell at a glance? Looks like the owner played a little trick on you."

What?

The merchants' eyes flashed.

Was Yeoahong normally that expensive?

Two silver nyang was enough to buy two seom[1331] of rice and drink strong liquor like water for several months. Mixing water into it was nothing short of outrageous.

"I'm going to—"

One of the merchants was about to spring to his feet, but his companion stopped him.

[1330] Yeoahong, literally "Daughter's Red," is a traditional Chinese rice wine.

[1331] A seom is a traditional Korean measure of grain volume, approximately 180 liters or 48 US gallons. Two seom is about 360 liters or 95 US gallons.

“Forget it. Nothing good will come from making a fuss. Besides, aren’t we doing the same thing—making a little extra while we can?”

“Ugh.”

The merchant groaned and sat back down.

Meanwhile, the young man was filling his cup to the brim with Yeoahong and gulping it down.

Gulp, gulp, clack!

“Ahh. That’s good.”

The merchants stared at him dumbfounded. Only after a moment did they finally come to their senses.

“What do you think you’re doing?”

“That’s our liquor…”

“My throat was a little dry, so I tried a cup. Is there a problem?”

His answer was so shameless that the two men were left speechless. They only managed to speak after the young man had emptied his third cup.

“Have we met before?”

“Of course.”

“When? Where?”

“Today, here.”

…

“They say even brushing sleeves with someone creates a connection. Starting today, let’s be friends.”

“Friends?”

The merchants glared at the young man in disbelief.

He was slender and had an approachable expression. He looked no older than his mid-twenties—just a ridiculously young brat.

What the hell does he mean, friends?

They were about to give him a proper tongue-lashing when they noticed the iron sword tucked into his waistband.

A martial artist!

People had always said there was only a fine line between a rogue and a martial artist.

With their merchant guards nowhere nearby, they would unquestionably be the ones to suffer if a dispute broke out.

The merchants swallowed the reprimand that had been about to leave their mouths.

“Listen, Young Brother.”

“Young Brother? I like that form of address.”

“R-really? That’s good, then.”

There was something strangely relaxed about the young man’s grin. Forced smiles appeared on the merchants’ faces.

“Are you a martial artist too, Young Brother?”

“Hmm. I have learned some trifling tricks people call martial arts.”

What? He learned ‘trifling tricks’ called martial arts?

The brat’s already drunk on his own swagger.

The merchants cursed him inwardly before speaking.

“You must be a future pillar of the martial world. If you don’t mind, may I ask which sect you are a Disciple of?”

“Does that matter between friends?”

The young man deftly dodged the question, so one of the merchants revealed their own identity.

“We are merchants belonging to the Geumwa Merchant Group.”

“The Geumwa Merchant Group?”

“It is nothing to boast about, but we are one of the top three merchant groups in Zhejiang Province. We came a long way to deliver supplies for the Star-Array Grand Banquet being held three days from now.”

The other merchant, who had been nodding beside him, eagerly chimed in.

“We even brought a hundred merchant-group guards.”

“Warriors as brave as tigers.”

We aren’t alone. Get lost before you get taught a lesson.

The words carried an unspoken threat, but the young man paid no attention.

More precisely, he was so absorbed in his own thoughts that he let their words go in one ear and out the other.

“The Geumwa Merchant Group… I definitely heard that name this morning.”

The young man thought for a moment, then exclaimed, “Ah!”

“Isn’t that the group that captured hundreds of bandits?”

“That’s right.”

The merchant had answered with his chest puffed out, but he added in a mumble, “To be precise, we didn’t capture them. We picked them up.”

“Picked them up? What does that mean?”

When the young man showed interest, the merchants lowered their voices as much as possible.

What they had encountered before meeting this young brat was far more troubling.

“Well, there were a bunch of bandits lying in the alley the merchant group was passing through, all with broken legs and groaning. As it turned out, they were from Black Mountain Stronghold, which is notorious in the area.”

“Their leader, the Red-Killing Axe Heuk Jongpil, had been turned into a headless corpse.”

“Oh?”

The young man rubbed his smooth, hairless chin.

“So what did you do?”

“What else could we do? We couldn’t exactly kill them all, but leaving them there would have been like throwing silver nyang onto the road. So we tied them all together in a line.”

In the end, the Geumwa Merchant Group handed the remnants of Black Mountain Stronghold over to the authorities and collected an enormous bounty. The rumor spread quickly.

“People have been saying all kinds of things. That they angered a hidden master, that a war broke out between bandit strongholds…”

“It probably was a hidden master. How many people can kill a Peak master like the Red-Killing Axe in One Strike?”

The young man listened quietly, then asked with keen interest, “A Peak master, killed in One Strike?”

The two merchants nodded together.

“That’s right. You’re a martial artist too, so you must know how remarkable that is.”

“What was it again? The underlings said whoever it was had chunks of iron dangling all over them. It was so late at night that they couldn’t make out the person’s face. They just saw a flash, and then the Red-Killing Axe fell.”

“Hmm.”

The young man fell silent for a moment, as though considering something. Then he suddenly spoke.

“That hidden master must be much younger than you think.”

“Good heavens. Do you have some idea who he might be?”

“More or less. Probably dressed in rags, with hair all over the place.”

“Oh! Who is it? Who is that master?”

“But I don’t know the name.”

…

“Well, I suppose I can get to know him little by little from now on. Thanks for the drink.”

It happened in an instant.

After casually tossing out that final remark, the young man rose from his seat and disappeared into the bustling crowd.

A moment later, the inn’s door closed with a tinkling bell.

“What was that?”

“Did he really leave? After gulping down all that Yeoahong?”

“He called us friends. Damn it.”

The two merchants were staring blankly at each other when someone spoke to them.

“Excuse me, gentlemen.”

“What is it?”

A broad-shouldered waiter held out a wooden tablet with an impassive expression.

There were scars across his face, enough to make one suspect that he moonlighted as a dark-path knife fighter.

No, with a face like that, it was practically certain.

“The gentleman who just left didn’t pay his bill. From what I just heard, it seems you two are friends.”

“Huh?”

“Two roast ducks and five bottles of Yeoahong. The total comes to ten silver nyang and twenty nyang in iron coins.”

“…!”

The merchants’ mouths fell open as though they had been struck squarely in the back of the head.

What the fucking hell?

He drank five bottles of Yeoahong?

But what could they do? If you could tell ten things from one, then the waiter’s face made it clear that this establishment was managed by a dark-path faction.

The merchants were rummaging through their coin purses with miserable expressions when—

“I’ll pay.”

Clink.

A silk pouch flew from somewhere and landed on the table.

The people inside the inn had fallen silent. Through the crowd, which had split cleanly down the middle, an old man came limping forward.

Tap, tap.

The sound of his wooden prosthetic leg striking the floor pierced everyone’s ears.

“Twenty silver nyang. Use it to pay the bill and get me a quiet room.”

The waiter looked back and forth between the silk pouch and the old man, then bowed politely. He already knew who the man was.

“Yes, Great Hero Song.”

“Well, that settles one matter.”

The old man wrapped his rough hands around the merchants’ shoulders.

His grip was so powerful that it was impossible to believe he was a man in his seventies. He seized the two men and hauled them to their feet.

“Now, the two of you and I are going to have a little talk. About that friend who just left.”

“Why—why are you doing this?”

“We have absolutely nothing to do with him!”

The old man smiled broadly at the two merchants, who were almost whimpering. But he could not hide the gravity in his deep-set eyes.

“Heh heh. Isn’t that something for this old man to decide?”

At the words of Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox, the merchants drew a sharp breath.

As if to announce that the Star-Array Grand Banquet was only three days away, the streets and inns throughout Henan Province were packed with people.

The problem was that, thanks to that, there was not a single room left for me.

“We have no rooms.”

I had already been turned away from more than twenty inns.

With nowhere else to go and no reason left to hold back, I glared at the waiter and asked, “You’re sure there really isn’t one?”

“I told you, there isn’t.”

“I have money.”

I pulled out a grimy silver nyang and held it up. It was my entire fortune and my last hope.

If I hadn’t secretly hidden it away in advance, I wouldn’t even have this.

Jeok Cheongang had run off with my entire coin purse.

Damn old man.

At the very first inn we entered, Jeok Cheongang had been showered with salt[1332] by the waiter. After agonizing over whether to set the waiter or the inn on fire, he had come up with a peaceful and spectacular solution.

The Abbot of Shaolin card.

I’m going to Shaolin.

Wow. That option was available? Was dementia the driving force that turned you into a genius?

Shall I use that driving force to snap your neck?

I shouldn’t have run my mouth. Anyway, that’s great. Let’s hurry there, scrub the dirt off with hot water, and eat some Shaolin wild-greens bibimbap.

[1332] Throwing salt at an unwanted visitor is a Korean custom intended to drive away bad luck.

I'm going alone.

What?

A year ago, you ran your mouth about going to the Star-Array Grand Banquet, and this old man suffered for it despite having no reason to. The preliminary competition will be held in Kaifeng anyway, so don't let me see your face until then.

No way! How is that fair?

Oh, and hand over your coin purse.

Why do you need my coin purse?

The Fire King has his dignity to consider. Do you expect me to arrive looking like a beggar and eat and bathe for free? I should at least make a small donation.

…

Oh, and if you come looking for Shaolin, I'll kill you. Understood?

He wasn't the Fire King. He was a highway robber. A highway robber.

After watching my coin purse get stolen right out from under my nose, I stood there blankly for a long while before wandering aimlessly in search of a place to sleep.

And this was the last inn anywhere nearby.

"This is real silver. Want to bite it and see?"

The heavily built waiter scowled.

"…Didn't you just pull that out of your underwear?"

"I was hiding it."

I quickly rubbed the silver nyang with my sleeve before holding it out again.

"Want to bite it?"

"Get the hell out of here, you beggar bastard!"

Fucking bastard…

I considered punching him in the face, but turned away weakly.

Nearby, several children were huddled together playing jacks with small stones.

"Kids, do any of your families rent out rooms?"

The chubby-cheeked children shook their heads.

"N-no."

"My family does, but it's already full."

"Oh, I see. All right."

"And my mom said not to bring in beggar bastards like youuu."

…

Listen to the way that little brat talks.

I wanted to storm into his house and yell at his parents to teach him some proper manners, but I held myself back.

Where do I go now?

I was slowly wandering the streets, wondering whether I should go wash myself in a nearby stream, when someone called out.

“Young Hero!”

At first, I didn’t realize they were calling me. Given my current appearance, it was far too absurd to think that someone would address me as a Young Hero.

My clothes were no better than rags, and my hair was a tangled mess. At that moment, I was a perfect specimen of a beggar.

At least I had avoided looking like a prisoner by winding the chains around my body and covering the iron balls with cloth.

But who would call someone like me a Young Hero?

“Me?”

When I turned around, I saw a young man with an approachable expression smiling brightly.

“That’s right. You.”

Chapter 242

He was a young man with an approachable expression.

He looked to be in his mid-to-late twenties at most, with a strangely friendly smile playing on his lips.

“Whew. Why are you walking so fast?”

“Do I know you?”

“No.”

“Then why?”

“They say even brushing sleeves with someone creates a connection, don’t they?”

“We haven’t even brushed sleeves.”

“But we’ve exchanged words, so that counts. Let’s be friends.”

“…”

It was one of two things. He was either crazy or a crazy social butterfly.

I took my time looking him over. Beneath his loose robe, I spotted well-developed muscles and the hilt of a sword jutting from his waist.

At the same time, I sensed the qi lying dormant within him.

A Peak master?

I had no idea how old he actually was, but his attainment was fairly impressive.

No, at this level, it could even be called remarkable. Reaching the Peak realm in your twenties was no easy feat.

But how should I put it? The qi I sensed from the young man seemed to amount to exactly that and nothing more.

If I had to put it into words…

An ordinary Peak master?

The Peak realm was already an incredible level, so why did he feel ordinary?

Because I was surrounded by too many monsters.

Getting hit with the insane three-hit combo of Jin Mukyung, Cheongpung, and the Fire King was bound to leave side effects like this.

In any case, I had more or less figured him out. I spoke politely to the young man.

“Don’t mind me. Go on your way.”

“Good heavens, isn’t that awfully cold between friends?”

“If we’re friends, can I drop the formal speech?”

“Haha. Of course!”

“Then fuck off, asshole.”

“…”

I left him behind and started walking. After standing frozen for a moment, he hurried after me in quick little steps.

“That was the first time anyone has ever insulted me. I was stunned for a moment. Yes, this is what true friendship is!”

“Just go while I’m still asking nicely.”

“What’s your name?”

“Michael Johnson.”

“That’s an unusual name.”

“…You believe that?”

“Jang Sam? Or Yu Pil? Are you perhaps a Disciple of one of the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families?”

“Why do you care?”

“Because I’m interested, of course. I heard you killed the Red-Killing Axe with One Strike.”

I stopped dead at the unfamiliar epithet.

“Who?”

“The Stronghold Lord of Black Mountain Stronghold. Was that your doing?”

I recalled the hairy bandit chief I had dealt with on the way here. There had been so many bandits that I had taken him out first to intimidate the rest.

I had thought he was unusually strong for a bandit. Apparently, he had been somewhat famous.

“But how did you find out?”

“I heard it from the Geumwa Merchant Group’s merchants at the inn earlier. They said the surviving bandits claimed it was the work of a strange man carrying iron balls and chains.”

The young man beamed as he pointed to the iron balls strapped to my back.

I had covered them with cloth to disguise them as luggage, since I did not want to invite any strange misunderstandings. But apparently, I could not fool the eyes of a Peak master.

“And then you happened to walk by. My curiosity got the better of me, so I came straight after you.”

“Hmm.”

“So, what’s your name?”

Should I tell him or not?

After a moment’s thought, I opened my mouth. I was beginning to grow curious about which sect this eccentric young man belonged to as well.

“Jin Taekyung. That’s my name.”

“Are you the Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Shanxi Province?”

“You know me?”

“Of course I do. I’ve heard so much about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi becoming the Fire King’s Disciple that my ears are ringing.”

A year could be short or long, depending on how you looked at it.

But it was more than enough time for rumors about me and the Fire King to spread throughout the continent.

“What about you?”

“Ah, as for me…”

The young man grinned and continued.

“Jongni Chu. I’m Jongni Chu from Yunnan. I have my reasons for not revealing my sect, so I hope you’ll understand.”

“Jongni Chu from Yunnan?”

“My epithet is the Always-Victorious Sword. Have you ever heard of me?”

I knew Yunnan, but this was my first time hearing his name or epithet.

Considering I had spent the past year holed up in Fire Gate Cavern, that was only natural.

“Sorry, but I haven’t.”

“Is that so? Well, it’s understandable that you wouldn’t know.”

Would you look at that positivity? Most martial artists his age would have been disappointed, but he showed no sign of it.

The freakishly positive guy continued with a serious expression.

“That’s because I just came up with the epithet. A swordsman who always wins. Isn’t it cool?”

“…”

Is he crazy?

As I stood there speechless, Jongni Chu made a motion of twisting his wrist.

“How about it? Shall we have a drink to celebrate becoming friends?”

“Not interested. Besides, there aren’t any seats at the nearby inns.”

“What are you talking about? I’ve been following you this whole time, and every inn had at least one or two seats open.”

“…The waiters said there weren’t any.”

“Hm? Then why did they tell me there were empty seats and invite me inside?”

“…”

Damn it. Of course.

Even with the Star-Array Grand Banquet right around the corner, how could every last seat in dozens of inns possibly be taken?

I’m washing because I’m filthy. Because I’m filthy.

I would have to draw water from a stream and wash myself. At this rate, I would end up sleeping on the street despite leaving perfectly good inns unused.

“I know a decent inn, so come with me. I’ll pay for the drinks to celebrate our new friendship.”

“What friendship? You said your name was Jongni Chu, right? You should go on your way too.”

It was not as though I was completely penniless. I had no intention of getting tangled up with some weirdo and wasting time chatting.

Hadn’t someone said there was a stream if I kept following this road?

As I searched my memory and walked on, Jongni Chu called after me.

“Hey, where are you going?”

“None of your business. Don’t follow me.”

“Then answer just one last question! Where can I see you again?”

“The Star-Array Grand Banquet.”

That was my final answer. I used qinggong[1333] and quickly left the area. After covering more than a hundred zhang[1334] in an instant, I heard Jongni Chu shouting behind me.

“See you next time!”

Not a chance, punk.

One man left, and one remained.

Jongni Chu stared in the direction Jin Taekyung had disappeared and murmured,

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung…”

Before long, a deep dimple formed beside his smooth, unlined mouth.

After standing there alone and chuckling to himself for a while, he turned toward an inn not far away.

The waiter who had driven Jin Taekyung off fifteen minutes earlier bent at the waist with a broad smile.

“Welcome!”

“Do you have any seats left?”

“Of course, sir!”

Jongni Chu’s smile deepened.

Splash!

When I sat up, the hot water filling the wooden tub sloshed around me.

I had found the battered old tub lying in the grass, filled it with cold stream water, and heated it with Scorching Yang Qi.

[1333] Qinggong is a martial-arts skill for moving swiftly and lightly.

[1334] A zhang is ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). More than a hundred zhang is more than 303 m (994 ft).

After dumping and refilling the water several times to scrub away the accumulated grime, I felt as though I had lost several kilograms[1335].

"I feel like I've undergone Bone Transformation[1336]."

I finally felt alive again.

It would have been nice to have shampoo or body wash, but this was more than enough to satisfy me.

The inventories for Murim and the modern world were separate, so bringing any over had been impossible from the start.

But these clothes are a problem.

I frowned as I put the rags back on. It was hard to tell whether they were clothes or garbage.

The discomfort was one thing, but putting these back on made the bath feel completely pointless.

I wandered through the streets, intending to buy at least one cheap set of clothes.

The streets of Henan had been crowded with people from every class and profession even a year ago, but given the timing, martial artists were especially conspicuous now.

Naturally, snippets of their conversations reached my ears.

"Have you heard? The Sword Dragon of the Namgung Family won't be participating in this year's Star-Array Grand Banquet."

"Good heavens. Why would the Sword Dragon suddenly drop out? Is there some sort of problem?"

"Who knows? It's a shame. He was one of the favorites to win. The outcome is getting harder and harder to predict."

"Among the young prodigies, the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes probably have the best chance, but…the age limit is thirty-five. There's no telling what will happen."

"That's a fair point. The world is vast, and there are many masters. A powerful newcomer from outside the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families could easily appear."

"You mean someone like the Heaven Shaking Sword of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

"Exactly. Though I don't know whether either of them will attend this year's Star-Array Grand Banquet."

Hearing them talk about me made my face burn.

I quickened my pace and left the road behind.

As soon as I reached a main street lined with large buildings, a cloth shop displaying silk and dozens of different outfits caught my eye.

[1335] One kilogram is about 2.2 lb.

[1336] Bone Transformation refers to an advanced bodily transformation in martial-arts fiction.

“Excuse me.”

“Why, they say clothes make the woman, but those suit you wonderfully. Are you perhaps a fairy? A fairy… What do you want?”

The cloth-shop employee had been enthusiastically showering a group of pretty female customers with flattery, but he frowned the moment I called out to him.

The change in his expression was so extreme that I barely resisted punching him in the face.

“Why do you think I came to a cloth shop?”

“To beg, obviously.”

“…”

No matter how ragged my clothes were, there was no hiding my massive frame.

If anything, the rags left so much skin exposed that my muscles stood out even more.

When I stared at him while subtly tensing my body, the employee flinched.

“W-why are you looking at me like that? Was I wrong?”

“That’s enough of the kind of remark you’ll regret. Let me see some clothes.”

“C-clothes?”

“Here. I have money, so don’t treat me like a beggar.”

The employee’s expression changed when I pulled out a silver nyang[1337] and waved it around.

Contrary to my expectations, it changed for the worse.

“That’s all?”

“It is. Is there a problem?”

“Good grief. What kind of clothes do you think you can buy with one lousy silver nyang[1338]?”

“…One lousy silver nyang[1339]?”

Had there been some major currency reform in the past year that caused the value of silver to collapse?

As I stood there in confusion, the employee snorted.

“Did you even read the price list before coming in?”

I reflexively turned and checked the sign.

A wooden board at the front of the shop had these words written across it in enormous letters:

[1337] A silver nyang is a historical unit of silver currency, not Korean won.
[1338] A silver nyang is a historical unit of silver currency, not Korean won.
[1339] A silver nyang is a historical unit of silver currency, not Korean won.

> **The owner has gone mad! Star-Array Grand Banquet special discount! Martial-artist's outfit—two silver nyang[1340]!**

"…Two silver nyang[1341]? For a martial-artist's outfit?"

"With that, you could buy underwear at best. Our cloth shop handles only the finest silk. Even our martial-artist's outfits are made from Shu brocade[1342]."

"…"

So this was a department-store brand.

Of all the places I could have walked into, I had chosen this one. What an embarrassment.

The other employees and customers inside the shop began whispering as they watched me.

"Oh my, he must be a beggar. How pitiful. Don't you agree, dear?"

"He certainly looks like one. He seems strong enough to put those muscles to use, though. Should we take him in as a servant?"

"You're so merciful, dear. I'm sure that beggar would be delighted."

Being called a beggar was irritating enough, but hearing it from a couple made me twice as angry.

I shouted with all the anger I could muster.

"Who are you calling a beggar?"

"Gasp!"

"Eek!"

"H-how dare you!"

People recoiled in fright at my booming shout.

At the same time, several burly employees came rushing over and surrounded me, brandishing clubs threateningly.

"You bastard! How dare you make a scene here!"

"Do you even know where you are, you filthy beggar?"

"What? A beggar? Oh, you sons of bitches…"

Fine. You said it.

I rolled up the sleeve that was already half torn off.

"All right, let's be a real pain in the ass today. Who owns this place?"

That was when it happened.

"You're the kind of bastard who won't come to his senses until he sees a coffin. How dare you make a scene here?"

A grave voice rang in my ears.

[1340] A silver nyang is a historical unit of silver currency, not Korean won.

[1341] A silver nyang is a historical unit of silver currency, not Korean won.

[1342] Shu brocade is a fine silk textile traditionally made in Sichuan, China.

I slowly turned around and saw a man.

He wore a bamboo hat pulled low over his face and black silk clothes embroidered with dragons. One hand rested on the hilt of his sword as though he might draw at any moment.

The lips visible beneath the bamboo hat curled as he let out a quiet laugh.

“You seem to have learned a move or two somewhere, but if you don’t want to see blood, step aside.”

I cocked my head.

“And if I don’t?”

“Nameless martial artist, the price of reckless bravado is death.”

The people nearby erupted in cheers at the line straight out of a martial-arts movie.

Once the cheering died down, I spoke.

“Hey, can I ask you one thing?”

The martial artist answered casually,

“Speak. They will be your last words.”

I stared into the shadow beneath the martial artist’s bamboo hat and continued.

“You’re Hyuk Mujin, right?”

“…!”

I let out a deep sigh and looked up at the sky. A signboard written in vigorous, soaring calligraphy caught my eye.

Hyuk Family Cloth Shop

“You have three seconds. Put your head on the floor.”

Chapter 243

Hyuk Mujin had been living a dream day after day. Every now and then, he even pinched his own cheek.

Mujin, are you really allowed to be this happy? This isn't a dream, is it?

He had every reason to feel that way.

Just over ten years ago, he had been nothing more than a boy who admired martial artists.

No, I don't need to go back that far.

Even two years ago, he had thought his life was a cesspool.

His working hours were long and tedious, and his martial arts had stagnated.

And when the person he saw most often was the drunken, good-for-nothing Third Young Master, anyone short of the Buddha himself was bound to take a bleak view of the world.

I held it in and held it in, then finally threw one punch.

The day he drove his fist into the Third Young Master's jaw, Hyuk Mujin's life changed.

Countless battles. One brush with death after another…

The Third Young Master—or rather, his Captain—was like a magnet that drew every danger in the world toward him.

Hyuk Mujin fought through the threats flying at them from every direction, and by the time he came to his senses, he had grown by leaps and bounds.

Ohhh, power! Power is surging through me!

…Patient, come over here. Your crazy spell is acting up again, so it's time for your beating.

Bam! Ba-ba-bam!

He had taken an awful lot of beatings, too. There had even been times when he secretly set out a bowl of pure water and prayed behind Jin Taekyung's back.

Please, please don't let the Captain hit me anymore. Just take him somewhere far away.

Had his prayer been answered?

One day, Jin Taekyung left without warning.

As Hyuk Mujin watched him depart with the Fire King, he felt both sad and liberated.

And at last, the prime of his life began.

You're Hyuk Mujin?

Gasp! Great Hero Wipeng, how do you know me…

Draw your sword. Let's see what you can do.

He began receiving instruction from Wipeng, the Peak master known as the Ghost Sword.

Did you say the Jin Dragon Squad?

That's right. It's made up of the family's finest. I've been appointed its Squad Leader.

Wow! The Jin Dragon Squad! Congratulations!

Pack your things.

Pardon?

You're the Vice Squad Leader. This is our lord's command, so you cannot afford a single mistake.

Gasp. I pledge my eternal loyalty to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. At your command! At your command!

He had become Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad, the Jin Family of Taiyuan's most elite unit.

A young man who had once dreamed of becoming the Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion had, in just a year or two, grown into a martial artist capable of standing shoulder to shoulder with the family's leading figures.

They truly had been dreamlike days.

…At least until a moment ago.

"You're Hyuk Mujin, right?"

"…!"

Wild hair. A thick, unkempt beard. A muscular beggar dressed in rags.

At the words that came from his mouth, Hyuk Mujin's hands and feet went numb.

That voice was unmistakably familiar. How had he failed to recognize it at once?

No wonder the back of his head had been itching strangely…

Where did it all go wrong?

Was it when he came to Henan as Jin Wikyung's escort?

Or when he accepted his father's request to inspect the Henan branch of the Hyuk Family Cloth Shop?

He didn't know. There was only one thing he could be certain of.

I'm fucked.

Cold sweat slid down his back as he heard the words that turned his journey to Henan into a journey to hell.

"I'll give you three seconds. Put your head on the ground."

His mind screamed no, but his body knew better.

Hyuk Mujin, a rising talent of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and Vice Squad Leader of its most elite unit, slammed his head into the ground with a thunderous cry.

"Yesssss, sir!"

Thud!

A white stone wall, with five or six rooftops visible beyond it.

The large estate where the Jin Family of Taiyuan was staying drew steadily closer.

“This the place?”

“…Yes.”

Hyuk Mujin answered in a half-dead voice. His once-impressive martial uniform hung in tatters, and one eye was swollen and bruised dark blue.

To borrow his own words from half an hour ago, this was the price of reckless bravado.

“Oh. You found a nice place to stay. The family must be doing pretty well these days.”

I wasn’t the only one who had changed over the past year. Hyuk Mujin had changed, and so had the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s standing.

The fact that they had rented an entire estate this large with the Star-Array Grand Banquet right around the corner told me all I needed to know.

“Lead the way, punk.”

“Urgh! That hurts! It hurts!”

“I’m kicking you because it’s supposed to hurt, punk.”

I walked along, booting him in the rear.

Two Jin Family martial artists standing rigidly on guard before the estate spotted their superior and gaped.

“Gasp!”

“Vice Squad Leader!”

Hyuk Mujin subtly averted his gaze and cleared his throat.

“Ahem. Have you been keeping proper watch? This gentleman is…”

Shing! Shing-shing!

“You bastard!”

“How dare you do this to our Vice Squad Leader!”

He was the Vice Squad Leader of some newly formed unit called the Jin Dragon Squad, and apparently his subordinates thought quite highly of him.

I gave the Jin Dragon Squad members pointing their swords at me an amiable smile.

“Put those away. I’m with the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Vice Squad Leader, are you all right?”

“Where did this beggar bastard come from, spouting nonsense?”

At his subordinates’ response, Hyuk Mujin nodded with a stricken expression.

“Not a beggar bastard. He’s the Third Young Master.”

Pardon?

“But no matter how you look at him, he’s a beggar…”

I could let it go once, but not twice.

Hyuk Mujin noticed my expression change and spoke gloomily.

“Hocheol.”

The martial artist named Hocheol promptly answered.

“Yes, Vice Squad Leader.”

“Put your head on the ground.”

“…”

Right. That was the least I could expect from my right-hand man.

Leaving Hocheol behind to commune with the earth, I stepped onto the estate grounds. Almost immediately, I came face-to-face with someone strolling through the courtyard.

“…!”

“…!”

His eyes trembled with emotion.

Even if ten years had passed instead of one, he would have recognized me. It wouldn’t have mattered how disheveled I looked.

That was what blood ties meant. That was what it meant to be brothers.

“Well, look who it is.”

The massive man staring at me, frozen like a statue, was Jin Wikyung. A radiant smile spread across his face.

He strode toward me and spoke.

“Are you from the Beggars’ Sect?”[1343]

“…”

Brothers, my ass.

“I recognized you at a glance, actually.”

“Are you kidding me?”

“I’m serious. Did you really think I wouldn’t recognize you, my youngest?”

“Do I look like a complete idiot?”

Don’t try to pull that on me. He had even asked what position I held in the Beggars’ Sect.[1344]

Jin Wikyung fidgeted under my stare, then turned to Hyuk Mujin.

[1343] The Beggars’ Sect is a martial faction of beggars, traditionally counted among the Nine Sects and One Gang.

[1344] The Beggars’ Sect is a martial faction of beggars, traditionally counted among the Nine Sects and One Gang.

“Vice Squad Leader Hyuk. Didn’t I send you a Sound Transmission earlier? I told you I was going to pretend not to recognize him and asked you to play along.”

“Ah, well, you see…”

“That’s what happened, isn’t it? Hmm?”

Hyuk Mujin furrowed his brow.

“Ow. Lesser Family Head, why are you suddenly stepping on my foot?”

“V-Vice Squad Leader Hyuk!”

“Aagh! It hurts!”

“…”

He was trying. He really was.

I didn’t need to look under the table to know exactly what was happening.

As I watched the two of them, a quiet laugh escaped me.

They haven’t changed.

Jin Wikyung and Hyuk Mujin.

They were the same two people I remembered. The events of the past year had lent them more experience and composure, but underneath it all, they were unchanged.

That alone was enough.

I wonder how everyone else is doing.

It didn’t take long to find out.

Jin Wikyung gave me a detailed account of everything that had happened since I left, including what had become of the people I had yet to see again.

Lee Seowol was still fighting to restore the Mount Heng Sword Sect to its former glory, while Wolhwa was building a city of entertainment in the relatively desolate reaches of northern Shanxi.

And then…

“Cheongpung is missing?”

“That’s right. Not long after you left, he set out for Huashan with the Three Plum Blossom Elites, but apparently ran away along the way.”

That wasn’t going missing. That was escaping.

From what I heard next, Cheongpung’s disappearance had caused quite an uproar.

An influential Elder from Huashan had even come in person to ask them for a favor—if they saw that Cheongpung bastard, they were to contact him.

“The sect’s most senior elder and its young prodigy vanished one after another. Their reaction was understandable. Just watching them made my heart ache.”

The Sword Saint and Cheongpung… At this point, shouldn’t I start wondering whether they were actually related by blood?

“Huashan is really thriving.”

"It's still doing better than our family."

"Why? Didn't they wipe out the mounted bandits in the north and continue to prosper? That sounds like they're doing pretty well to me."

Jin Wikyung shook his head gloomily.

"Huashan at least has a Sect Leader and plenty of disciples. Our Family Head's seat is vacant."

"Oh."

"Perhaps that's why their situation didn't feel like someone else's problem. We agreed to help each other from now on. Struggling martial factions have to support one another."

So that was how they ended up helping each other out.

I thought of the man who had been missing for years—the Family Head—then promptly erased him from my mind.

In this Murim, he might be my father, but I had never even seen his face. He was a complete stranger.

I felt no familial affection for him, much less any desire to see him.

If I see him, I see him. If not, whatever.

Instead, I was far more concerned about Jin Mukyung, whom I'd traded snarls with every chance we got.

"Come to think of it, where's Second Hyung?[1345] Did he go somewhere?"

Quite a bit of time had passed, but he still hadn't appeared.

Wipeng might have stayed behind to guard the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Jin Wikyung's absence, but Jin Mukyung should definitely have come…

"He's in closed-door training."

"Huh? Again?"

"Still would be more accurate."

"…You mean he's been in there this whole time?"

I was dumbfounded when Jin Wikyung nodded.

In martial-arts novels, everyone and his dog spent decades in closed-door training or meditating before a wall, but anyone who actually tried it would quickly realize it was nearly impossible.

Even a single year would be unbearable without extraordinary mental fortitude.

When did Jin Mukyung enter closed-door training?

It had been right after he lost his duel with Cheongpung, which meant he had been in there for a year and six months by now.

[1345] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

For all that time, he had not taken a single step out of the dark training hall. He had devoted himself to ceaseless training, surviving on water and fasting pills for all three meals.

"Could he have been in there so long that he lost track of the date? Maybe he didn't know about the Star-Array Grand Banquet."

"I went to see Mukyung before we left and told him about it. I asked if he wanted to come with us."

I didn't need to hear his answer. Jin Mukyung's absence told me everything.

Jin Wikyung continued in a low voice.

"He said he wouldn't leave until he achieved Great Completion. He asked me to tell you that."

Great Completion…

To Jin Mukyung, the Star-Array Grand Banquet was a fruit he could reach simply by stretching out his hand.

He was already one of the foremost young prodigies in the Central Plains. If he entered, he could prove his martial arts and win even greater fame.

But Jin Mukyung had chosen his martial arts over that sweet fruit.

He's an incredible guy.

While everyone else reached for the fruit and scrambled up the tree, Jin Mukyung had turned his back on it and devoted himself to training.

And one day, when his training was complete, he would possess not the fruit, but the tree itself.

A tree laden with fruit.

Yeah. That's a true martial artist.

I respected his choice. I didn't know what lay at the end of the path Jin Mukyung had chosen, but I believed its direction was more correct than anyone else's.

That was enough.

I murmured with a sigh.

"So that's how it turned out."

"Are you disappointed?"

"A little. I was hoping the three of us would get together again."

"Even without those two, the world is full of exceptional masters. The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes are right there, aren't they?"

"I guess."

At my lukewarm response, Jin Wikyung smiled faintly.

"Then I'll have to turn that disappointment into joy."

Pardon?

"I brought you a present."

A present? As I stared at him in confusion, Hyuk Mujin rose from his chair.

A short while later, he returned carrying something long and tightly wrapped in thick cloth.

“Do you know what it is?”

Of course I did. The moment I saw it, my heart began to pound and my fingertips twitched.

It was instinct.

Not Jin Taekyung’s instinct, but a spearman’s.

“This is…”

“Fifteen days ago, Elder Jang Taebo handed this to me and said something.”

Shrrk.

As Hyuk Mujin peeled away the cloth, Jin Wikyung’s voice rang in my ears.

“He said he finally understood how Gan Jiang and Mo Ye must have felt.”[1346]

Vrrrrm.

The spear let out a low hum.

[1346] Gan Jiang and Mo Ye are a legendary husband-and-wife pair of swordsmiths from Chinese lore.

Chapter 244

I had loved the sea ever since I was a child. I loved its distinctive salty scent that pierced my nose, and I loved standing still and watching the waves crash against the shore.

And now, there was a sea inside me.

The qi sea.

Another name for the dantian.

As always, I swam through that endless sea of qi.

I took hold of the horn of the fire dragon curled within my dantian, leisurely made the rounds of hundreds of acupoints, then opened my eyes.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have successfully completed circulating your qi!
The realm of the Scorching Sun Divine Arts has risen to the sixth stage!
All Fire Gate Clan martial arts have become more refined and powerful!
All fatigue has been cleared, and all stamina has been restored!
Level Up!

Finally, the sixth stage?

I neither saw nor heard any of the other System notifications. The only thing that mattered to me was that the realm of the Scorching Sun Divine Arts had reached the sixth stage.

This is where the real thing begins, right?

The Fire Gate Cavern had been created by the first Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan for his successors.

Filled with fire energy, it was ideal for absorbing Scorching Yang Qi and particularly well suited to learning the Fire Gate Clan's greatest martial arts.

Simply put, it was a double-EXP event zone.

But even that place had a clear limit.

Hmm.

"Why are you groaning like a dog that needs to take a dump?"

That was from a conversation I'd had with Jeok Cheongang around six months after entering the Fire Gate Cavern.

At the time, I was brimming with confidence after achieving the remarkable feat of reaching the third stage of the Scorching Sun Divine Arts.

“Oh, it’s nothing. I was just wondering whether I should spend another year in closed-door training here.”

“Here? In the Fire Gate Cavern?”

“Yes.”

“What about the Star-Array Grand Banquet?”

“I’m improving by leaps and bounds here. Why would I leave? If I stay just one more year… Why are you looking at me like that?”

“It’s nothing. I was merely marveling at how much of a blockhead you are.”

“That sounds like a pretty big deal to me.”

Jeok Cheongang looked at me as though I were hopeless, then let out a deep sigh.

“Do you know how old this old man is?”

“If even you don’t know, how would I?”

“I am one hundred and one years old this year.”

“Oh. One hundred and one Dalmatians.”

“I swear by the ancestors of the Fire Gate Clan, if you spout one more piece of nonsense, I’ll throw your body into the sacred flame as firewood.”

“…Yes, sir.”

“In any case, even this old man, who has lived for so many years, remains at the eighth stage. What was that you were saying?”

“Wait. The eighth stage? Haven’t you already achieved Great Completion?”

“Do you think a divine art is called a divine art for no reason? Although your progress is fast, even the martial arts that can be learned in the Fire Gate Cavern have their limits. In the case of the Scorching Sun Divine Arts, that limit is precisely the fifth stage.”

“…Then what comes after that?”

“Martial arts are like weapons. You must sharpen and hone them without end. The only answer is to gain enlightenment through countless hardships and experiences.”

“Then I should at least reach the fifth stage of the Scorching Sun Divine Arts before our time here is up.”

“Would you look at this greedy brat. Reaching the third stage in a mere six months is already an incredible achievement. Don’t start spouting nonsense just because you have the Heavenly Martial Physique.”

“How long do you think it’ll take me?”

“Who knows? It took this old man exactly five years to go from the third stage to the fifth… Even with the Heavenly Martial Physique, it should take you two years.”

Exactly six months later, I found myself staring at a half-dazed Jeok Cheongang.

“T-This can’t be happening. It makes no sense.”

“But it did happen. Did it really take you five whole years?”

“You little bastard! I was one of the greatest geniuses of my generation!”

“Yeah. Heavenly Martial Physique.”

“This is impossible! Why did it have to be someone like you!”

Remembering Jeok Cheongang howling in despair, I let out a quiet laugh.

Putting the old memory aside, I rose and stood before a large full-length mirror.

Reflected in it was a perfectly proportioned body with compact, powerful muscles, hair carelessly twisted up and tied, and a clean-shaven chin.

It would’ve been fine if I’d left it alone.

Now that the thick beard was gone, my face felt oddly bare. But there had been no overcoming Jin Wikyung’s forceful insistence.

“The Star-Array Grand Banquet is a gathering watched by every martial artist under heaven. The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi is appearing in the Central Plains, and you plan to go out looking like this? It’s a crime!”

I had thought he was being a little dramatic, but after getting it cut, I liked this better.

Whatever else anyone might say about this body, its face was ridiculously handsome.

You look like a gisaeng’s brother.[1347]

I was inwardly muttering the highest compliment one man could give another when I suddenly realized I had forgotten something.

Clink.

“Oh, right. These.”

The shackles, iron chains, and iron ball I had continued to drag around even after arriving at the estate of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I gazed silently at the objects that had practically become parts of my body, then opened my mouth.

“Inventory open. Summon.”

Whoosh!

The next moment, a solid spear shaft filled my hand.

The weapon summoned from my Inventory was a spear approximately two meters long.[1348]

Perhaps because it had been forged from an enormous quantity of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, it gleamed with a beautiful, translucent light from the spearhead to the butt of the shaft.

[1347] Gisaeng were traditional Korean entertainers trained in music, dance, and the literary arts; the phrase refers to a handsome, delicate-looking man.

[1348] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.

“White Flame.”

Vrrrrm. Vrrrrm.

As though it had recognized its own name, a faint vibration traveled from within the shaft.

White Flame was a weapon forged solely for me by Jang Taebo, the former Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild and a man hailed as the greatest smith under heaven.

Perhaps that was why White Flame was special.

Both to the naked eye and in the System window.

However…

“Captain, it’s time to leave.”

As Hyuk Mujin’s voice outside the door reminded me, it was time to go.

Sunlight flooded the world outside the window, and the people of the Jin Family of Taiyuan—including Jin Wikyung—were moving about busily.

“All right.”

As I answered, I choked up on the spear and slashed.

With four streaks of light, everything that had bound me for the past year fell away. The shackles, chains, and iron ball rolled noisily across the floor.

Clatter! Boom!

Bang!

Startled by the tremendous noise, Hyuk Mujin opened the door and rushed in.

“What was that?”

“Nothing. Let’s go. Oh, bring the chains with you.”

“…You’re planning to tie me up with those, aren’t you?”

“Those chains are made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.”

“Gasp! They’re mine. Mine!”

Clicking my tongue, I stepped outside. Jin Wikyung sat astride a large black horse, and he grinned when he spotted me.

“Let’s go.”

“Yes.”

Our destination was Mount Song.

There, the curtain would rise on the Star-Array Grand Banquet, an event drawing the attention of the entire Murim.

“Yah!”

Jin Wikyung and I led the way, with fifty members of the Jin Dragon Squad following behind us.

Through the rushing wind, someone’s distant cry echoed faintly.

“Wait! Wait for me! Don’t leave me behind!”

"…"

I still couldn't believe that bastard was the Vice Squad Leader.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, muttered with an annoyed expression.

"…Does this old man really have to attend something like this?"

The Dharma King, Hong Dao, was sitting with an endlessly benevolent expression.

"This old monk is bored enough to attain Buddhahood, so keep your mouth shut and sit still."

"Why? You said you were bored too."

"I am already bored. What do you think will happen if an old man with little time left starts whining beside me like a seven-year-old child?"

"I would get annoyed."

"Exactly. If I become both bored and annoyed, I may smash my wooden fish[1349] and return to my quarters."

"You've attained enlightenment."

"Amitabha.[1350] Amitabha."

Tok. Tok. Tok-tok-tok-tok…

The clear sound of the wooden fish echoed through the room. Those who had been listening with pricked ears looked utterly dumbfounded.

They say the Fire King and Dharma King are famous for their eccentric behavior. I can see why.

Those two haven't changed at all.

Why won't that old bastard just die?

Their thoughts differed, as did their clothing and the auras they exuded.

Some were middle-aged men without a single white hair, while others were old men with heads of pure white.

The dozen or so people gathered there, each so different from the others, were not ordinary mortals.

They belonged to the fifteen pillars supporting the Murim of the present day: the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was already familiar with some of them.

"Oh, if it isn't Family Head Namgung."

Namgung Ryong, the Family Head of the Namgung Family, rose and offered a fist-and-palm salute.

[1349] A wooden fish is a wooden percussion instrument used in Buddhist practice.

[1350] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

“Please forgive my late greeting. The two of you were having such an entertaining conversation that I found myself listening…”

“It’s fine. I left in a hurry last time and didn’t even get to see your face. My apologies.”

“Not at all. I am the one who should apologize.”

“So, is your son competing in this Star-Array Grand Banquet?”

“He won’t be able to compete this time.”

“That’s unfortunate.”

Jeok Cheongang’s face showed not the slightest trace of regret as his gaze shifted to the man beside Namgung Ryong.

“Who are you?”

The man with the sycophant’s beard asked sourly, “Are you speaking to me?”

“Yes. You, with the beard like a sycophant’s.”

“I am Gong Iljung, Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect.”

“Ah. Are you that fellow they call the Wind-and-Cloud War God or something?”

“Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord.”

“What does that matter? Young man, why are you so rigid?”

Gong Iljung, a “young man” who had long since passed sixty, had to steady his breathing.

Only a year earlier, he had been shocked when the Roaring Fury Swordsman—his Senior Brother, who had studied under the same Master—returned with a severe Internal Injury.

But he had to endure it. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was quite literally a mad tiger.

“Did you hear about it from your Senior Brother?”

“…Yes.”

“Keep him under control so he doesn’t come to my attention. Shoving him into the Repentance Cave for about twenty years might not be a bad idea.”

Gong Iljung barely managed to swallow the curse rising to his lips.

What Jeok Cheongang meant was that he could easily live another twenty years, so Gong Iljung had better not act up.

Even those who normally regarded Jeok Cheongang with displeasure inwardly clicked their tongues.

What a vicious old man…

Is he planning to live forever?

You’ve caused enough trouble. Go already, old man. Let the rest of us breathe.

I should have brought my Master.

They might have belonged to different sects, but the Murim had a strict order of seniority.

Jeok Cheongang was a figure from two generations earlier, which naturally placed his seniority far above theirs.

That was one reason the leaders gathered there could do nothing but tremble before him, no matter how much they dominated the world.

Martial arts, seniority, or verbal skill—there was not a single area in which they could beat him.

“Ahem. Ahem.”

“Erhm.”

Several people were clearing their throats to avoid Jeok Cheongang’s questions when a booming voice rang out.

“Hahahaha! With the tiger away, the fox has been playing king. Jeok Cheongang, have you been well?”

Jeok Cheongang turned toward the thunderous voice, his brow already deeply furrowed. He knew exactly who had arrived.

“Goddammit. You’re still not dead?”

“Listen to the way this little old man talks.”

An enormous old man threw back his head and laughed. Although his mouth split open in a broad grin, his sharp eyes swept over Jeok Cheongang.

“I welcomed a great-great-grandson not long ago. There’s no chance I’ll die before I see that boy get married.”

“A great-great-grandson?”

“What, are you jealous? My great-grandson’s wife is Hebei’s greatest beauty, and the boy looks just like his mother. He’s adorable.”

Jeok Cheongang replied with an indifferent expression.

“The greatest beauty in that neighborhood can’t be trusted. Isn’t Hebei the place where anyone with fists this big and a thick waist gets called Yang Guifei?”[1351]

“What!”

“Anyway, congratulations. With ten children, I suppose you’ll never have to worry about heirs.”

“…What kind of bullshit are you trying to pull?”

“What do you mean? To celebrate seeing your great-great-grandson, why don’t you change your title while you’re at it? Forget Thunderbolt Saber King. How about Virility Saber King?”

“GRAAAAGH! You old man!”

“Sit down while I’m asking nicely. Don’t you remember breaking your bones when you challenged me during the Great Faction War?”

Sssshhhh!

[1351] Yang Guifei was a Tang-dynasty imperial consort celebrated for her beauty.

Powerful waves of qi poured from the two Supreme Peak masters. Their auras were so overwhelming that everyone present felt a chill run through them.

If the Dharma King had not been there to mediate, blood might have been spilled.

“Now, now. Amitabha, Amitabha… Both of you, calm yourselves. The heroes outside are waiting. How can you make such a disgraceful spectacle? Do you wish to smear the names of the Fire Gate Clan and the Hebei Peng Family with shit here today?”

His final words proved effective. The two men hesitated, then withdrew their auras.

“Ahem. Jeok Cheongang, I’ll teach you a lesson next time.”

“I’ll be waiting, Virility Saber King.”

Having delivered the final blow to the Thunderbolt Saber King’s title, Jeok Cheongang leisurely walked away.

The Dharma King, the Thunderbolt Saber King, and the overlords of the various regions followed behind him.

They passed through a corridor draped in blue cloth and stepped out into the blazing sunlight.

Three zhang[1352] below, tens of thousands of people gathered at the foot of Mount Song greeted them with a tremendous roar.

“Waaaaaaah!”

[1352] A Chinese zhang is approximately 3.33 m (10.9 ft); three zhang is about 10 m (33 ft).

Chapter 245

Waaaaaaah!

The deafening roar of tens of thousands of martial artists made my ears ring.

They had gathered here to attend the Star-Array Grand Banquet, each carrying dreams of rising to prominence, and their cheers seemed endless.

The noise, which seemed as though it would never end, gradually died down the moment Dharma King Hong Dao raised his hand.

In that hand was the Green Jade Buddha Staff, the symbol of a thousand years of Shaolin. Shaolin Temple was the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim, and its immense authority silenced the crowd.

The old monk's deep voice, infused with profound internal energy, spread across the grounds.

"I often look up at the sky. Over the long years, I have seen, read, and watched countless stars."

I had heard something once.

They said the greatest reason Dharma King Hong Dao had become the Abbot of Shaolin was not his formidable martial arts, but his learning and wisdom.

"The Star-Array Grand Banquet. If you wish to become the brightest star at this banquet, think brightly and act brightly."

After a brief silence, he added one short sentence.

"That is how one survives even in darkness."

The shorter a congratulatory speech, the better. Better still if it contained a hint of profound wisdom, and better yet if the speaker was the Abbot of Shaolin.

Another roar of cheers and applause erupted.

"Waaaaaaah!"

As I watched, I suddenly wondered how many of the tens of thousands gathered here had actually understood what he meant.

Probably one in ten.

No, not even one in a hundred.

But I understood. I knew what Hong Dao's words referred to.

Dark Heaven.

My training in the Fire Gate Cavern had been harsher than everything I had endured before it combined.

Jeok Cheongang had pushed me relentlessly, so much so that he had seemed not merely impatient, but downright anxious.

At first, I had thought it was because of his infirmities of old age.

But before long, Jeok Cheongang revealed something after much deliberation. Only then did I understand his urgency.

Dark Heaven. A powerful enemy that had yet to reveal its true nature.

We don't have much time. Keep training and preparing. That is the best thing you can do.

I looked at the old man standing to Hong Dao's right.

His small frame was noticeably different from Hong Dao's, yet he gave off an overwhelming presence. Jeok Cheongang somehow spotted me and flashed a crooked grin.

He looked visibly older than he had a year ago. My chest churned before I knew it.

You'd better know you're dead if you don't win.

"…"

Especially if you run into some bastard with the surname Peng. Beat the shit out of him. Break him and tear him apart!

A cold wind swept through my queasy chest.

One dose of the Fire King's motion-sickness medicine, delivered through Sound Transmission, cured me completely. I quietly looked away.

Until I arrived, I had been fairly confident. But seeing the sheer number of martial artists with my own eyes made it difficult to guarantee victory.

I'd better not answer. If I give him a definite answer and then lose, he'll ride my ass even more.

In any case, the opening address was over, so the preliminaries would begin soon.

Like a salmon swimming upstream, I pushed through the tightly packed martial artists toward the back. Then I spotted a familiar face.

"Huh?"

What was that guy's name again?

Oh, right. Jongni Chu of Yunnan. The guy with the self-styled epithet Always-Victorious Sword.

I had wondered why he had come all the way here from some remote backwater. Apparently, he had come for the Star-Array Grand Banquet after all.

With his skills, he should make it pretty far.

I considered saying hello, but decided against it. It seemed like it would only become a hassle.

Instead, I sent a greeting to the guy standing blankly and looking around, one he could not hear.

Yeah. Good luck to you too.

And prayed that, if possible, he wouldn't run into me.

"I like duels. There are winners and losers, but no draws. What could be more clear-cut than that?"

The middle-aged man muttered in a relaxed voice.

A pair of glasses imported from the Western Regions[1353] rested on his nose. They had the marvelous ability to make objects appear several times larger, which naturally made them extremely expensive.

“That’s why people bet money on them. The result is certain.”

Gambling was an inseparable part of the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

From the preliminaries, which filtered out the unqualified among tens of thousands of applicants, to the finals, hundreds of duels would be held.

For that reason, the Star-Array Grand Banquet was not only a feast for the martial artists of the world. It was also the greatest season of the year for gamblers across the continent.

“So, who would you like to bet on, and how much?”

The bald man sitting across from the middle-aged man asked the question. At a glance, he looked like someone with one foot in the underworld, but his manner was polite.

“You’re still as impatient as ever.”

“We have a lot of customers waiting.”

“I see. Well, let’s see…”

After a moment’s pause, the middle-aged man pulled a money pouch from his robes and tossed it onto the table.

Unable to withstand the weight, the pouch opened, and gleaming silver yuanbao[1354] spilled across the tabletop with a clatter.

“A thousand silver nyang[1355] on the Iron-Water Divine Dragon of the Yangtze River Channel League.”

“…”

It was an enormous sum.

Especially considering the preliminaries had not even begun.

The middle-aged man’s nerve was clearly extraordinary.

The bald man’s eyelids trembled as he stared at the silver yuanbao[1356].

“Are you betting on the Iron-Water Divine Dragon to win the whole thing?”

“Of course not. Cheol Soo may be one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, but he’s not capable of that yet. His Master, the Seafaring King, would be another matter.”

“Then…?”

“I’m betting he’ll take first place in the preliminaries.”

“Hmm.”

[1353] The Western Regions is a historical East Asian term for lands to the west of China, especially Central Asia.

[1354] A yuanbao is a Chinese ingot used as money.

[1355] A nyang is a traditional Korean unit of currency. It is not a Korean won.

[1356] A yuanbao is a Chinese ingot used as money.

The bald man let out a low groan.

The preliminaries of the Star-Array Grand Banquet were commonly called a “sieve.” With so many applicants, those below the required level had to be filtered out.

Naturally, judging tens of thousands of applicants created countless possible outcomes.

Which also meant the odds would be enormous.

“That’s different from what you said earlier.”

“How so?”

“You said you liked duels because there were only winners and losers, making the result clear-cut.”

“You really shouldn’t gamble.”

The middle-aged man laughed heartily before continuing.

“That’s the kind of wager third-rate gamblers make. All or nothing. One of the two sides is bound to win, so there’s a limit to how much you can earn. But who am I?”

“A Dogon.”

“Exactly. That’s why I like duels. People want the easy road. They don’t want the difficult one.”

“Ah.”

A gambler among gamblers. A gambler who had reached the Peak of his craft was called a Dogon.

The middle-aged man had come here with a conclusion drawn from meticulous research and calculation.

The bald man bowed deeply in admiration.

“I’ve learned a great deal, Great Hero Kwak.”

“If you learned something, you should pay the tuition.”

“What would you like?”

“Keep your mouth shut, just as you have until now.”

“Of course.”

“Then that’s enough. Let’s see… The preliminaries should be starting soon. I’ll have a drink and come back to collect my money.”

He had absolute confidence that his prediction would prove correct.

That was a Dogon for you.

The middle-aged man pushed up his glasses and left.

A swordsman guarding the door, practically dying of curiosity, cautiously asked, “Boss, who was that?”

“That gentleman? A Dogon.”

“Gasp! A Dogon?”

"And one of the most renowned Dogons in the world."

"Is he really that incredible?"

"There are exactly three legendary Dogons."

The bald man spread three fingers.

"A-Gwi[1357] in Sichuan. Jjak-Gwi[1358] in Guangdong. And the last one…"

One of his fingers folded down.

"On a continental scale, that gentleman. Kwak Cheolyung."

"Kwak Cheolyung…!"

"So go keep an eye on the Iron-Water Divine Dragon. Now that I think about it, that rookie's gotten pretty damn cocky."

Whack!

The bald man kicked the swordsman in the shin.

A short while later, he welcomed his next customer. This one was rather strange, with a mask pulled up over his nose.

"Where would you like to place your bet?"

"Will this be kept confidential?"

The masked man's voice was uneasy.

He flinched as if people beat him up every chance they got. Anyone could tell at a glance that he was a Third Rate martial artist.

The area around his eye is all black and blue. Someone must've worked him over pretty good. Well, as long as I get paid, it's none of my concern.

A gentle smile spread across the bald man's lips.

It was his professional smile, the one that appeared automatically whenever he saw a sucker.

"Of course. Go ahead."

The masked man glanced around nervously before pulling out a money pouch.

"A hundred silver nyang[1359] on Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, taking first place in the preliminaries."

"Those from there to here, follow me."

The Star-Array Grand Banquet had so many participants that it required hundreds of supervisors and multiple testing grounds.

More than a hundred applicants followed their assigned supervisor. Naturally, I was among them.

[1357] A-Gwi means "hungry ghost," a being in Buddhist tradition.

[1358] Jjak-Gwi is a Korean nickname meaning "one ear."

[1359] A nyang is a traditional Korean unit of currency. It is not a Korean won.

There really are a lot of people.

Not only were they numerous, but they came in every possible variety.

There were skinny people and fat people, fresh-faced youths with downy hair and wandering martial artists who looked as though they had been through every hardship imaginable. There were women who immediately drew the eye and handsome men with flawlessly smooth features.

A hundred people, a hundred different appearances. The saying fit perfectly.

One massive man stood out even among that crowd. He looked like the very definition of a man's man, and judging by our eye levels, he was at least a head taller than me.

Fuck, is this the continent or Norway?

He stood over two meters[1360] tall. His forearms bulged with enough muscle to look ready to burst, and one bore a tattoo of a salmon impaled on a harpoon.

Even his features looked oddly Western. He looked so much like a Norwegian that I began to wonder if he actually was one.

I stole a sideways glance at him, only for our eyes to meet.

"…"

"…"

I cautiously opened my mouth.

"Ah, aim fine, thankoo. An' yoo?"

"…?"

That wasn't it. What was it again?

I had stopped studying English after my elementary-school red-pen workbooks,[1361] and now I was so nervous the words barely came out.

"Ah! Where are you from?"

Norway answered.

"You fucking asshole, what are you doing?"

"Oh, I'm sorry."

"You little shit, are you picking a fight with me right now?"

A hearty stream of curses and the gazes of everyone around us came flying my way.

Just as I was about to answer, the supervisor shouted sternly.

"Anyone who causes trouble will be forcibly disqualified!"

Norway opened and closed his mouth like a salmon as he glared at me.

Then a strand of Sound Transmission reached me, carrying an aura and killing intent as rough and sharp as a harpoon.

I'll make you regret this.

[1360] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

[1361] Red Pen is a Korean home-study workbook brand.

Talk about vicious. A true descendant of the Vikings.

Still, I was the one in the wrong.

I bowed my head in apology and continued walking. A forceful snort sounded behind me, but I pretended not to hear it.

He's pretty strong, though.

He looked to be in his twenties, yet he was already a formidable opponent. My pulse quickened at the thought that I had encountered someone like him right from the start.

The world really is wide.

If the preliminaries were already this intense, genuine monsters might come crawling out during the main event. Remembering Jeok Cheongang's warning, I steeled my resolve.

"The first thing we will assess is your fist-and-foot techniques."

The supervisor led us to an unnamed cliff.

I did not need to ask how the test would be conducted.

Other applicants were already taking it.

Whack! Crack!

"Graaagh!"

A foolish martial artist with his wrist twisted rolled across the ground. The supervisor sighed and broke a bamboo marker.

"Jangyu of the Butterfly Sect, eliminated. Next!"

The next martial artist stepped forward and punched the cliff.

Boom!

This martial artist was around the First Rate level. At least he knew how to put internal energy behind his strike.

A clear mark appeared on the cliff, which was a hard-packed mixture of roughly equal parts rock and soil.

The supervisor measured its depth and width, then nodded.

"Gobul of the Sodang Sect, passed. Next!"

Those who passed moved aside, while Third Rate martial artists whose punches left faint marks—or who hurt their hands with a single blow—were eliminated in droves.

"You've seen enough to understand how this works. Let's begin. Now, let's see…"

The supervisor pulled out a bamboo marker.

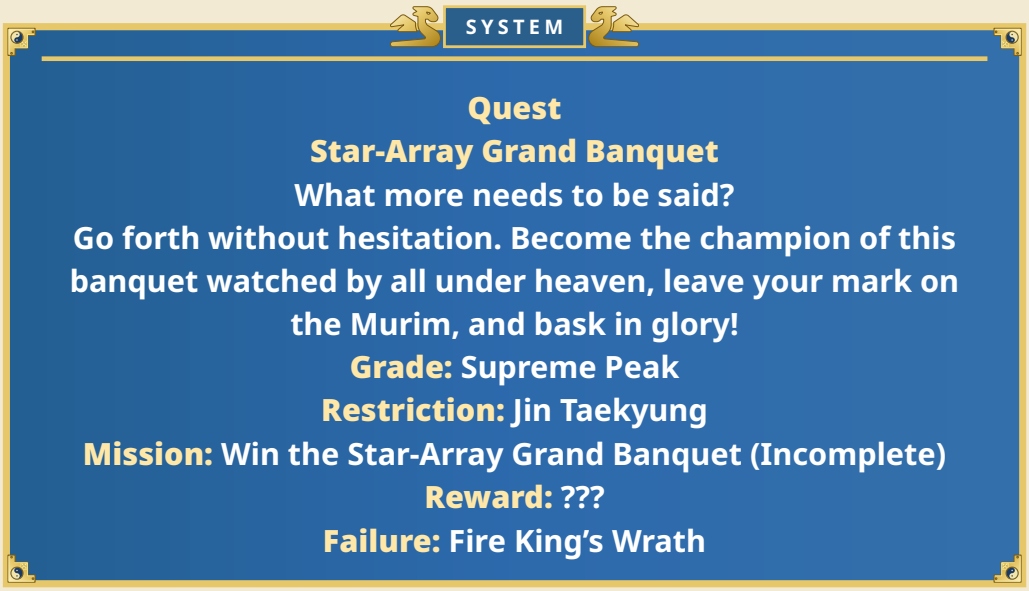
Then he called a name.

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

As the gazes of the people around me turned toward me, a System notification rang out.

Ding.

Chapter 246



"…"

I paused at the penalty for failure.

I mean, I might not win the Star-Array Grand Banquet. Is that really something to get angry about?

Imagining Jeok Cheongang flying into a rage left me feeling a little wronged.

Especially after teaching me for barely a year.

Granted, I was an extremely unusual case.

Even so, the fact that the Quest window went out of its way to spell it out suggested just how much Jeok Cheongang expected of me.

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Where are you?"

"Oh, here."

At the supervisor's call, I closed the Quest window and stepped forward.

With every step I took, I felt the people's gazes on me. Along with them, murmuring voices pierced my ears.

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan…"

"The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

"Is that him? The young man the Fire King took as his Disciple?"

"That's him. I'm sure of it."

I also heard Norway's familiar gruff voice.

"Hmph. So you did have something to rely on. You may look the part, but you're still a weakling."

Ignoring the whispers from every direction, I stopped in front of the cliff.

The supervisor, who had been staring at me in surprise, addressed me in a suddenly more respectful tone.

“If the mark is at least three Korean inches[1362] deep, you pass. Anything less is a failure.”

“Yes.”

Three Korean inches[1363] was roughly ten centimeters.

Any ordinary First Rate master who had consistently trained in fist techniques should be able to pass without much trouble.

But now that it was my turn, I found myself growing tense.

Damn. I have no idea how much force to use.

I honestly had no clue. Exactly how much strength did I need to apply to leave a mark three Korean inches[1364] deep?

After staring at it for a moment, I decided to use the Help function.

“Excuse me, Supervisor.”

“Yes?”

“As long as I make the mark at least three Korean inches[1365] deep, I pass, right?”

“That is correct. However, once your fist lands, the test is over.”

“Oh, I see.”

Well, that makes it easy.

I nodded, placed my fist against the cliff, and gave it a gentle push.

Thump! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The cliff face split as softly as tofu. Fragments of rock and clumps of dirt came pouring down.

With my arm buried up to the elbow, I looked at the supervisor.

“I pass. Okay?”

“…”

The supervisor’s expression was a sight to behold.

His mouth hanging open, he looked back and forth between my face and the arm embedded in the cliff. Then he stammered out a question.

“H-How did you do that?”

“I pushed.”

“I mean, how did you…”

“I just put some strength into it and pushed.”

“…”

[1362] A Korean *chi* is 3.03 cm (1.19 in). Three *chi* are about 9.09 cm (3.58 in); the prose rounds this to 10 cm (about 3.94 in).

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[1365] A Korean *chi* is 3.03 cm (1.19 in). Three *chi* are about 9.09 cm (3.58 in); the prose rounds this to 10 cm (about 3.94 in).

"Anyway, I passed, right? My fist never left the cliff, and it went in plenty deep."

"W-Well…"

The supervisor's pupils wavered.

"I-I'm not entirely sure. Nothing like this has ever happened before."

"Then it's settled. This is how you handle it from now on."

"Y-Young Hero Jin, I'm sorry, but could you do it a little more normally? I'm finding it rather difficult to judge…"

"Normally?"

I did it this way because I don't think I can do it normally, you idiot.

I was wondering whether I should just throw a moderately powerful punch when —

"Bwahahaha!"

The sudden burst of laughter made everyone, myself included, turn toward it.

Norway, the massive man who stood out from the crowd, was looking at me with open mockery.

"You're desperate to stand out, aren't you?"

I scratched my chin and answered.

"Not particularly. But why are you so desperate to pick a fight with me?"

"You?"

"Yeah. You."

A vein bulged on Norway's forehead.

"I heard the Fire King's Disciple had only just passed the age of twenty."

"I'm twenty-two. I'm all grown up."

"I am thirty."

"Thirty? That's pretty close to my age. Wanna be friends?"

"How dare a fresh-faced brat like you…"

Does he have a fetish for honorific speech or something?

He glared and stepped forward, but the supervisor moved to stop him.

"Control yourself!"

"To hell with self-restraint. The only person who can speak to me like that is my Master."

I leisurely folded my arms.

"So this is what you've been dying to tell us. Fine, let's hear it. Who's your Master?"

"The Seafaring King."

The Seafaring King? Could it be…?

I cried out in shock.

"Jang Bogo!"[1366]

[1366] Jang Bogo was a ninth-century Korean maritime commander and trader.

"What the fuck are you talking about? My Master's name is Pa Ryun! The Seafaring King, Pa Ryun!"

"Oh. Right. Of course not."

Unlike me, who was disappointed, everyone else reacted strongly to the name that had just come out of Norway's mouth.

A stir spread among the applicants and supervisors in our group. Even the people being tested more than ten jang[1367] away began to murmur.

"Th-The Seafaring King, Pa Ryun!"

"Pa Ryun, the Alliance Leader of the Yangtze River Channel League and one of the Ten Kings?"

"Then that young man must be the Iron-Water Divine Dragon. No wonder he dared to pick a fight with the Fire King's Disciple."

"What is going on over there? Two disciples of the Ten Kings in the same group…"

Norway—or rather, the Iron-Water Divine Dragon—snorted at their reactions.

He was probably proud to have such an impressive Master, but pride in his own abilities also showed in every one of his actions.

Well, he's certainly strong enough to justify it.

Perhaps that was only natural for the Disciple of one of the Ten Kings.

Unlike me, he also seemed to have trained under the Seafaring King, Pa Ryun, since childhood.

I didn't know exactly how powerful the Yangtze River Channel League was, but he had clearly received unstinting support—martial arts, elixirs, and everything else he could need.

As I watched with my arms folded, the Iron-Water Divine Dragon gave a short laugh.

"So you're the Fire King's Disciple? Don't get cocky just because you come from some provincial martial family and received a mere year of instruction."

He wasn't exactly wrong. Shanxi Province lay on the outskirts, far from the Central Plains, and the Jin Family of Taiyuan was indeed a provincial martial family.

That may be true, but…

"You're a pirate. And your Master is a pirate chief."

"A pirate? How dare you insult the Yangtze River Channel League! We are heroes who roam the rivers and the open sea!"

"Sure. But boil that down to two syllables and you get 'pirate,' don't you?"

"You insolent wretch! What kind of vile nonsense is that? The heroes of our League are worlds apart from such scum!"

[1367] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *chi*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“Worlds apart? Do you guys eat those weird-looking fruits,[1368] too? The ones that make you unable to swim?”

“You son of a—!”

“You ate the Son-of-a-Bitch Fruit.”

Crack-crack-crack.

A vicious sound came from the Iron-Water Divine Dragon’s enormous fist.

He glared at me with killing intent in his eyes and stepped forward. The supervisor hurriedly moved between us.

“Wait! If you fight here, you’ll be disqualified—!”

“Move.”

“Gasp!”

Given the scale of the Star-Array Grand Banquet, every supervisor overseeing the examinations was a formidable martial artist, ranging from Supreme First Rate to Peak.

The supervisor assigned to our group was at Supreme First Rate, but the moment the Iron-Water Divine Dragon seized his shoulder, his face turned deathly pale.

“W-What is this…”

“You don’t need to stop me. My Master gave me strict orders to win the Star-Array Grand Banquet, after all.”

“Th-Then…”

“I’m not going to fight. I’m only going to show that brat one move.”

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon released the supervisor and strode toward the cliff. Without the slightest hesitation, he pushed his fist into it.

Craaaack!

Shattering the solid rock, he drove his arm in up to the forearm. Then he looked at me and clicked his tongue.

“This is all you accomplished.”

I had known it from the moment I first saw him, but the Iron-Water Divine Dragon was a master of exceptionally advanced external martial arts.

His size and strength couldn’t be explained by natural gifts alone.

Martial arts had built that body—an external qigong technique of the highest order had tempered it.

“Whoa…!”

“As expected of the Iron-Water Divine Dragon!”

Exclamations rang out at a feat of strength worthy of being called divine.

[1368] This refers to Devil Fruits in the Japanese series *One Piece*. They grant powers but leave those who eat them unable to swim.

Even an ordinary Peak master would have found it impossible without using internal energy. Yet the Iron-Water Divine Dragon had done it as easily as breathing.

And, as if to make a point, he had created a hole far deeper than mine.

“The Fire King’s Disciple is impressive too, but is he still outmatched?”

“That’s understandable. He’s much younger, and it’s only been a year since the Fire King took him as his Disciple.”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi must have been aiming to win as well, but… it looks like that’ll be difficult this time.”

Whatever the people around me were whispering, the Iron-Water Divine Dragon was undeniably impressive.

Regardless of who his Master was, no one could dispute that he was skilled enough to hold his head high anywhere in the Murim.

Clap, clap, clap.

“Now that’s some strength. Congratulations on passing.”

“Pathetic. There’s no need to force yourself to act calm.”

“I mean it.”

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon snorted at my applause and turned toward the supervisor.

After one unbelievable spectacle after another, the supervisor was still dazed.

“Did I pass?”

“Ah. W-Well…”

“It doesn’t matter. I had no intention of stopping here anyway.”

Rumble-rumble-rumble.

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon pulled his arm free with absurd ease and looked around.

Reading the envy, jealousy, and despair in the gazes fixed upon him—the looks people reserved for the strong—he bared his teeth at me.

“Brat, consider it an honor to witness the Ship-Breaking Fist.”

“The Ship-Breaking Fist?”

He didn’t answer.

Instead, internal energy as vast as the open sea surged in waves from his entire body.

His waist, thicker than a bear’s, and his pillar-like arms bent far backward. Blue internal energy, like a flowing river, already surged around his fist.

Gooooong.

The air around us trembled.

Then—

Kkwaaaang!

The Ship-Breaking Fist.

A single punch capable of splitting a sailing ship slammed into the cliff.

A deafening boom rang out, followed by a storm. People covered their faces with both arms and groaned as dirt and fragments of rock rained down.

“Gasp!”

“Urgh!”

Amid the chaos, I stood perfectly still and watched without missing a thing.

That was why, when the dust cloud finally settled, I could fully understand the cries of astonishment that erupted around me.

Wow…

The cliff stretched over a hundred jang[1369] in both height and width, a natural formation that had stood there for countless years.

Now, a massive hole had appeared where none had existed before.

No. It would be more accurate to call it a small cave.

It was over ten jang[1370] across in every direction and five jang[1371] deep.

“I-I can’t believe it.”

“This is the Seafaring King’s unique martial art…!”

An unmistakable tremor passed through the crowd.

Everyone gathered here revered martial arts above all else and yearned to grow stronger.

Their awestruck gazes converged on the martial artist who had just displayed a level of martial arts they couldn’t hope to approach.

“Huff. Huff.”

His broad back heaved. Muscles swollen to the point of tearing rippled beneath his skin.

After catching his breath for a while, the Iron-Water Divine Dragon turned around with a composed expression.

A single short question slipped between his thick lips.

“The result?”

Only then did the supervisor come to his senses and barely manage to speak.

“P-Passed. You passed.”

“I see.”

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon’s lips curled upward as his gaze swept over the crowd.

The heat in his eyes had yet to fade. Finally, they stopped on my face.

“Did you see that?”

[1369] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *chi*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1370] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *chi*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1371] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *chi*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

I gave a small nod.

“What did you think?”

“It was impressive.”

“And?”

“Hmm. Congratulations on passing.”

“That’s all?”

“What else? You want me to pat you on the ass?”

Grind.

At the sight of the Iron-Water Divine Dragon grinding his teeth, my head instinctively shook from side to side.

I told him it was impressive. What more does he want from me?

What is he, a fucking child?

Maybe it was because he was a pirate, but he was as simpleminded as they came. The fact that he had poured out enough strength to leave himself breathless during the preliminaries was just as ridiculous.

I clicked my tongue inwardly and spoke to the supervisor.

“Let’s keep things moving. We’ve already wasted quite a bit of time.”

“Ah, yes. Understood. Then, next…”

I was turning away as the supervisor called the next name when the Iron-Water Divine Dragon spoke again.

“Looking at you, I can tell what level the Fire Gate Clan is.”

“What?”

I stopped without meaning to. The Iron-Water Divine Dragon continued in a mocking voice.

“Single-heir succession. No teaching to outsiders. It sounds grand, but in the end, aren’t you running away from me like a fucking dog with its tail between its legs?”

“That’s your opinion.”

“Is it only my opinion?”

“What?”

I suddenly looked around.

Countless gazes surrounded the Iron-Water Divine Dragon and me.

I could read the emotions in their eyes.

Disappointment. Contempt.

Beep.

SYSTEM

People are whispering after seeing how terrified you look!
People are beginning to doubt the reputation of the Fire Gate Clan.
People are beginning to doubt the reputation of Jeok Cheongang.
Fame decreased by 18!
Fame decreased by 20!
Fame decreased...

The System notifications pierced my ears.

At that moment, I came to my senses as though waking from a long sleep.

So that's how it is.

For a moment, I had forgotten.

No—I had known, but I hadn't truly understood what it meant.

Even though the curtain had risen on the Star-Array Grand Banquet, this magnificent and dazzling stage where the martial artists of the world had gathered in one place…

This is the Central Plains. This is the world.

A world where everything was proven through strength alone.

Winners and losers.

A world divided into those two kinds of people.

That was the Murim.

"Hoo."

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon sneered when he saw me heave a sigh deep enough to sink the ground.

"Looks like you're finally ready to give it a try."

"Yeah. Thanks. That really woke me up."

"I heard you're fairly skilled with a spear. I'll graciously permit you to…"

"You called it the Ship-Breaking Fist, right?"

"Huh?"

"It might be able to split a ship, but a cliff is beyond it."

Whoosh.

One step.

The distance of five jang[1372] vanished.

By the time my foot touched the ground again, I had already passed the Iron-Water Divine Dragon.

[1372] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *chi*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

A belated cry of shock came from behind me.

“You—!”

Instead of answering, I looked up at the cliff before me.

The fire dragon sleeping in my dantian awoke and surged through every limb and bone. Hundreds of acupoints grew scorching hot.

“Jin Taekyung!”

“You fucking weakling. Consider it an honor to witness the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.”

Blue flames filled my vision.

Chapter 247

In a dank underground gambling den, a middle-aged man sat in a corner, fiddling with a set of bone tiles. His head drooped.

"…I'm done for."

A pair of glasses—an item imported from the Western Regions—rested on his nose. Until a few days ago, they would easily have been worth dozens of silver nyang.[1373]

Not anymore.

The lenses, said to magnify objects several times over, were cracked like rice paddies in a drought.

Two men watched him from a distance.

"Is that him? Is he really…?"

"That's Kwak Cheolyung. No doubt about it."

"Good heavens. I never thought I'd live to see one of the legendary Dogons in person."

One had narrow, birdlike eyes, while the other sported a goat's beard. Otherwise, they were ordinary gamblers of the sort one could find anywhere.

As they watched Kwak Cheolyung shuffle the bone tiles again, the goat-bearded man asked, "But what happened to him?"

It was a fair question. Kwak Cheolyung looked dreadful.

His face was haggard, and his beard had gone untrimmed. His silk clothes were black with grime and torn in several places.

They said he had spent his entire life moving from one gambling table to another, amassing an enormous fortune along the way.

Now, however, he looked like nothing more or less than a gambler who had lost everything.

"Did something happen?"

"It did. Something serious."

The narrow-eyed man nodded. Unlike the goat-bearded man, who had arrived in Henan late, he knew exactly what had happened to Kwak Cheolyung recently.

"What was it? Don't keep me in suspense. Tell me."

"He lost a bet."

"Winning and losing are common in this business, aren't they?"

"They are. But what if a thousand silver nyang[1374] were at stake?"

[1373] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

[1374] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

“Gasp! A thousand silver nyang[1375]!”

The goat-bearded man’s eyes widened.

That was enough money for someone to live in luxury for the rest of his life—no, enough for three generations to live like kings.

Regretting that he had missed such a massive game, he smacked his lips and asked, “It must have been the biggest wager since the founding of the country. Who was his opponent? A-Gwi? Or Jjak-Gwi?”

“My friend, I already knew you were hard of hearing, but you’re completely out of touch with recent news. A-Gwi had his wrist cut off by a fellow called the Mount Qingcheng Guillotine a couple of months ago, and Jjak-Gwi disappeared long ago.”

“Then who besides those two could possibly have beaten Kwak Cheolyung?”

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.”

“Who?”

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. The Fire King’s disciple.”

The Fire King was one of the Ten Kings and a Supreme Peak master whose reputation resounded throughout the world. There was no reason for such a man’s disciple to gamble with a Dogon.

The goat-bearded man thought for a moment before crying out as if in a groan.

“Dodo![1376] He played Dodo[1377] at the Star-Array Grand Banquet.”

“Correct.”

The Star-Array Grand Banquet’s betting games were considered the greatest gambling matches anywhere under heaven, and were therefore called Dodo.[1378]

At last, the goat-bearded man understood what had happened and clicked his tongue.

“Tsk, tsk. Kwak Cheolyung did something stupid. The odds on the preliminaries may have been high, but he should have realized that meant the risk was high, too.”

“Do you think he bet without thinking? He must have had his reasons for being confident.”

“What did he bet on, and against whom?”

“The Iron-Water Divine Dragon taking first place in the preliminaries.”

“I suppose he’s strong, being the Seafaring King’s disciple, but I don’t think he’s quite that good.”

[1375] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

[1376] “Dodo” is the Star-Array Grand Banquet’s term for a gambling match; the name repeats the Chinese character for “gamble” (□□).

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[1378] “Dodo” is the Star-Array Grand Banquet’s term for a gambling match; the name repeats the Chinese character for “gamble” (□□).

The narrow-eyed man shook his head.

“He seems to have gained some insight recently. I heard the Iron-Water Divine Dragon blew away a tenth of a cliff with his Ship-Breaking Fist.”

“…Is that even possible?”

The goat-bearded man had heard tales of Murim masters shattering the earth and cleaving the sky, but he had never imagined they were capable of anything like that.

While he was still reeling in astonishment, the narrow-eyed man said something even harder to believe.

“What’s so impossible about it? Right afterward, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi brought down the entire cliff.”

“…!”

The goat-bearded man asked haltingly, his eyes as wide as plates.

“H-He brought down a cliff?”

“That’s right. According to the witnesses, the whole thing came crashing down.”

“…”

The goat-bearded man said nothing. He merely stared at his friend in disbelief.

“Isn’t that just a wild rumor?”

“Everyone else, myself included, dismissed it as one at first. A man of flesh and blood bringing down a cliff with his bare hands? It didn’t seem possible.”

“Exactly.”

“But what can we do when it’s true? Kwak Cheolyung sitting over there is living proof.”

“Why would Kwak Cheolyung be proof…? Ah. He must have lost a thousand silver nyang.[1379]”

“Five thousand.”

“What?”

“What do you think it feels like to lose money in a game you were certain you’d win?”

“C-Could it be…?”

“Is Kwak Cheolyung any different from the rest of us? In the end, he’s just as addicted to gambling.”

The narrow-eyed man looked at Kwak Cheolyung with pity.

The disheveled man was staring blankly at the tiles in his hand.

“Three days ago, when the Iron-Water Divine Dragon withdrew from the Star-Array Grand Banquet and returned to the Yangtze, Kwak Cheolyung completely lost his mind.”

[1379] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

“Did he keep playing Dodo?[1380]”

The narrow-eyed man nodded.

“After the Iron-Water Divine Dragon, Kwak Cheolyung chose Jong Sam of the Hunroe Leg. He bet on him receiving the highest score in the leg-technique assessment.”

“That Peak master who was said to have no equal in kicks throughout Guangxi?”

“Yes. Though by now, he probably has quite a few equals. One of his legs was broken.”

“Don’t tell me the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi did that, too.”

“Are you starting to understand? That’s right. The two of them got into a minor dispute and agreed to exchange one clean blow each before calling it even. But one kick from the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi supposedly broke Jong Sam’s shin.”

“H-How?”

“I don’t know. They say he gave it a casual kick, and the shin snapped with a crunch.”

“…”

“The Hunroe Leg even struck first, but the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi just scratched his calf a few times afterward, and that was it. And next was probably…”

The stories that continued to pour from the narrow-eyed man’s mouth about the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi were nothing short of shocking.

The Kunlun Sect’s Kunlun Cloud Dragon, said to possess the finest qinggong[1381] among all the young prodigies under heaven, leaped five jang[1382] from a standing position—only to come crashing down with Jin Taekyung’s foot planted on his face.

The Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar flew into a rage when he could not close the distance between himself and Jin Taekyung during the movement-technique assessment. Unable to contain his anger, he grabbed Taekyung by the back of the neck and was promptly beaten like a dog.

“The fifth assessment was mechanisms and formations. This time, everyone was certain the Zhuge Clan’s Lesser Family Head would take first place, but…”

The goat-bearded man, who had been listening with a vacant expression, cut him off.

“It was the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi again, wasn’t it?”

“Exactly.”

“But seriously, how? What kind of freak is proficient in mechanisms and formations, too?”

[1380] “Dodo” is the Star-Array Grand Banquet’s term for a gambling match; the name repeats the Chinese character for “gamble” (□□).

[1381] *Qinggong* is a martial-arts movement skill associated with light, swift leaps and travel.

[1382] A *jang* is ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Five jang is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

“He isn’t. He’s just proficient in martial arts. The ignorant bastard had no idea what anything was, so he smashed everything in his path and forced his way through.”

“…”

“Anyway, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi took first place in the preliminaries, and Kwak Cheolyung, who bet on someone different every time, was left completely penniless. I heard he sank all the money he’d earned into it, then even mortgaged the estate and land where he’d planned to retire to borrow from loan sharks… Tsk, tsk.”

The narrow-eyed man gazed at Kwak Cheolyung with sympathy.

Only a few silver nyang[1383] sat before the legendary Dogon who had once amassed a tremendous fortune. They were probably all he had left in the world.

“Whether you earn it or lose it, it all happens in one shot. Isn’t that right?”

Only then did the goat-bearded man come to his senses. He licked his parched lips.

“Five thousand silver nyang.[1384] Whoever won that must have hit the jackpot.”

“He certainly struck it rich. Why else would they call him the Gold-Faced Young Master?”

“The Gold-Faced Young Master? Did he bet on the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

The narrow-eyed man nodded.

“He has incredible foresight. He must have won tens of thousands of silver nyang[1385] from this Dodo[1386] alone. Why else would he go around wearing a mask made of gold?”

“Good heavens.”

“They say he hasn’t even turned thirty yet… I suppose some men are simply destined to succeed.”

“Damn it. Some of us have reached this age without even owning a proper house. Hoo…”

The two men let out a deep sigh.

Then a chair scraped across the floor as someone rose to his feet.

Kwak Cheolyung staggered out of the gambling den. All he held were a few iron coins[1387] he had received as a consolation handout.

[1383] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

[1384] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

[1385] A silver nyang is a historical silver currency unit, not Korean won. Its value cannot be converted using a modern won exchange rate.

[1386] “Dodo” is the Star-Array Grand Banquet’s term for a gambling match; the name repeats the Chinese character for “gamble” (□□).

[1387] Iron coins are lower-value currency than the silver nyang mentioned earlier.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet was a long race, lasting at least half a month and sometimes as long as a full month.

After the three-day preliminary assessments ended, the applicants were given a day of free time.

That included me.

“Ahem. Ahehem!”

“Youngest! Youngest!”

“Captain! Captaiiin!”

“…Oh, please.”

Don’t. Don’t shout in a place this crowded. I’m already dying from all the attention, and now you’re making even more people stare.

Tap-tap-tap-tap!

I hurried toward my companions as quickly as I could.

As though he had been waiting for me, Jin Wikyung’s bear-like bulk charged forward with both arms spread wide.

“Youngest! My wonderful little brother!”

Whoosh! Grab!

The moment his bear paw locked around my upper body, Hyuk Mujin seized the back of my hand and rubbed his cheek against it.

“Ohhh, Captain! Top scorer in the Star-Array Grand Banquet preliminaries! The pride of the Jin Family of Taiyuan! The beacon of Shanxi Province! Our Captain! My lord!”

“…”

Jin Wikyung is my brother, so I’ll let it slide. But what the hell is wrong with Hyuk Mujin?

Doing my best to hide my bewilderment, I asked, “Are you out of your mind?”

“Yes. I’m insane! Your strength has driven me mad!”

“Are you seriously crazy? Let go. Let go already!”

Whack! Whack! Whack!

Even after I struck the crown of his head three times at lightning speed, Hyuk Mujin refused to budge.

Tears welled in his eyes from the pain, but he still would not release my hand.

“Thank you! Thank you for hitting me!”

“…Are you into that kind of thing?”

I had only heard rumors about people who took pleasure in being hit.

I had always wondered why he had never left despite the countless beatings I had given him. Now that I considered the possibility that he was one of those people, a chill ran down my spine.

“Respect-Your-Preferences Fist!”

Thump!

The blow landed squarely on Hyuk Mujin’s temple, and he collapsed to the ground.

At the same time, something bright and glittering slipped from inside his robes and landed on the floor.

“Huh? A gold mask?”

What is this now?

Is it a prop for that kind of play?

With a grave expression, I tucked the mask into my robes.

Hyuk Mujin, you dangerous bastard. This mask is confiscated for life.

Not a chance.

As I steeled my resolve, I noticed someone I had momentarily forgotten.

“Ahem. Ahehem!”

“Do you have a throat problem?”

Jeok Cheongang, who had been staring off at a distant mountain and repeatedly clearing his throat, flinched.

“W-What nonsense are you spouting?”

“You’ve been coughing this whole time.”

“Ahem!”

He kept looking away, clearly wanting to say something but pretending otherwise. The corners of my mouth rose on their own.

“I did well, didn’t I?”

“…”

“Perfect scores in all five assessments. Unanimous first place overall. That pretty much says it all, doesn’t it?”

“Ahem. Don’t get so pleased with yourself over something so trivial. Anyone could have done it, so stop making a fuss.”

“I heard it was the first time in the history of the Star-Array Grand Banquet.”

“These were merely the preliminaries. Have you forgotten what this old man told you? The world is vast, and there are many masters.”

“I beat three of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon of the Yangtze River Channel League. The Kunlun Cloud Dragon of the Kunlun Sect. And finally, the Divine Marvel Dragon of the Zhuge Clan.

The Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar was a master comparable to them, and the Hunroe Leg was a Peak master who had already made a brilliant name for himself throughout Guangxi.

Their backgrounds and specialties were all different, but the five of them now had one thing in common.

“I beat every last one of them.”

“That…”

For a moment, Jeok Cheongang was at a loss for words. Then he shook his head again and again.

“Bah. Pathetic weaklings.”

“I’m the strong one.”

“There you go, acting cocky again.”

“Could you just tell me I did well? I brought honor to you—Old Master, no, Master—and to the Fire Gate Clan.”

“You still have a long way to go!”

His words were stern, but the corners of his mouth were twitching.

It was obvious that he was barely holding back laughter.

I would have known that even without the Sound Transmission Jin Wikyung sent me a moment later.

—Don’t let it bother you too much. It seems he already went and bragged about you to the leadership to his heart’s content.

“Ahem!”

As if he had overheard us, Jeok Cheongang cleared his throat again at the perfect moment. Forcing a stern expression onto his face, he said, “Do not grow arrogant merely because you defeated a few nobodies. Compose your body and mind, and prepare for the main event. Understood?”

He was right.

Only the preliminaries had ended. The main event, where the true masters would reveal themselves, had not even begun.

Among those who had passed through the sieve of the preliminaries, there were likely quite a few masters comparable to the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes—or even stronger.

I had already spotted several such people while watching the assessments.

The world really is vast. He was right about that.

Anyone who had concealed their true ability during the preliminaries was not only strong, but clever.

I grinned and gave Jeok Cheongang a fist-and-palm salute.

“I’ll keep that in mind, Master.”

“That boy. Ha ha. Ahem!”

An unmistakable smile appeared at the wrinkled corners of Jeok Cheongang’s mouth.

Chapter 248

Hong Dao, the Dharma King, sat dozing in the main hall when his eyes suddenly opened.

The first thing he saw upon waking was the small back of someone standing motionless, gazing up at the Buddha statue.

“When did you get here?”

“About fifteen minutes ago, I suppose.”

“So, did you go see your proud Disciple?”

Jeok Cheongang answered gruffly without turning around.

“What Disciple? How many times do I have to tell you? He isn’t.”

“Oh, so you are proud of him.”

“Ahem. Of course he should be able to manage at least that much. What’s so special about the Star-Array Grand Banquet preliminaries?”

“You’ve never done anything like that yourself.”

“There was nothing like this in my day. Back then, even the orthodox factions were busy fighting among themselves, going on about the Southern Murim and Northern Murim.”

“That’s true.”

Hong Dao stretched. Cracks echoed from all over his body.

“Still, this is enough to make a ghost wail. I didn’t sense your presence at all. Have you grown even stronger since I last saw you?”

“Why would a ghost wail? Buddha should be furious. The Abbot of Shaolin is dozing in the main hall like a sick chicken.”

“Don’t be so hard on me. We’re growing old together.”

Jeok Cheongang turned around and shouted.

“Who says I’m old? You should have kept up with your martial-arts training. Look at me. Don’t I look spry enough to last another ten years?”

Hong Dao studied Jeok Cheongang, then rolled his prayer beads between his fingers.

“Benefactor Jeok. May you be reborn in the Pure Land.[1388]”

“Look at this damn bald monk!”

Hong Dao let out a quiet laugh at his old friend’s reaction.

“I don’t know about ten years, but you should be fine for another three.”

“Was that the heavenly patterns or whatever telling you?”

“The heavenly patterns? According to what this poor monk saw long ago, you should have died years ago.”

[1388] The Pure Land is a Buddhist realm into which devotees hope to be reborn.

"What?"

Jeok Cheongang's face hardened. He could tell from Hong Dao's expression and manner that he was serious.

"Why didn't you tell me sooner?"

"Because the flow changed."

"The flow changed?"

"The heavens are vast, yet ever-changing. Just as your star was beginning to lose its light, a Morning Star rose in the northern lands."

"…Jin Taekyung. So it was that boy."

"The heavenly patterns told this poor monk that the Fire King stood in the Morning Star's path. I have watched for the past year, and so it proved. Your star now shines brighter than ever."

Everything that had happened flashed through Jeok Cheongang's mind.

He had grown old and suffered from the infirmities of old age. He had begun searching for Jangcheon, whom he had sent away long ago, so he could settle his final affairs before leaving this world.

He had intended to deal with his former Disciple—who might still be committing evil somewhere in the world—with his own hands, then entrust the Fire Gate Clan's future to the Sword Saint of Huashan.

And then…

I met him.

The infirmities of old age were both the curse of passing years and an illness of the heart.

When Jeok Cheongang was about to let go of the word *life*, a hand named Jin Taekyung reached out and caught it.

And so Jeok Cheongang changed.

The more he watched that talkative, reckless boy, the more the ember lingering in a corner of his heart flared back to life.

Longer. I want to live longer.

To do that, he had to free himself from the infirmities of old age that gnawed at his mind with every passing moment.

Over the past year, he had immersed himself more deeply in martial arts. He learned while teaching, and gained insight through contemplation.

Jin Taekyung was not the only one who had grown in the Fire Gate Cavern. Jeok Cheongang had taken another step forward as well.

"Three years…"

Jeok Cheongang's low voice echoed through the main hall.

"I'll turn those three years into ten soon enough. No, a hundred."

Hong Dao burst into hearty laughter.

“That’s excessive greed. How long exactly do you intend to live?”

“I don’t know. I’ll somehow keep dragging myself along and live.”

“You’d have to undergo Bone Transformation about three times.”

“Damn it. Then I’ll just have to settle for ten years. So you hang on until then, too. You still need to show that you’re going strong.”

Hong Dao silently rolled his prayer beads.

“We are already waves that have flowed past. The Spear King, who was once so robust, and the Wave King, who was more spirited than anyone, have already left this world. The others have grown old enough, too. Someone whose whereabouts are unknown may already be dead.”

The Ten Kings was the name given to the ten Supreme Peak masters who had swept across the Murim during the Great Faction War.

Some had been worn away by time. Others had died at the hands of their enemies.

Though they were called the Ten Kings, there were only eight in reality, and they were now old enough to prepare for death.

Jeok Cheongang let out a low groan, then suddenly shouted.

“Enough of that defeatist talk! What’s with all this gloom?”

But Hong Dao opened his mouth with a peaceful expression.

“Unnamed. I entrusted him with the Green Jade Buddha Staff last night.”

“…!”

“By the time he finishes his preparations in Arhat Cave and emerges, he should have grown into a worthy vessel. I have already chosen someone to serve as Abbot until then.”

“W-What did you say?”

Jeok Cheongang found himself stammering.

The Green Jade Buddha Staff was a sacred treasure handed down through Shaolin for a thousand years. Hong Dao had not only entrusted such a treasure to his Disciple—he had even chosen the next Abbot.

To Jeok Cheongang, Hong Dao looked like a man preparing to lay everything down and leave.

“You bald monk. Are you, by any chance…”

Jeok Cheongang let the end of his sentence trail off, but what he meant to say was easy enough to guess.

A faint smile touched Hong Dao’s lips.

“This poor monk intends to step down after this Star-Array Grand Banquet. If the heavens permit it, I may cling to life for another year or so. But no longer than that.”

“The heavenly patterns… Is that what they told you?”

“I need to rest. Please leave for today.”

"Hong Dao!"

"Amitabha.[1389]"

Hong Dao picked up his wooden fish and began striking it. The clear notes echoed through the main hall, silencing Jeok Cheongang. Only after a long while did he finally turn and leave.

The three days of preliminary assessments had done their job admirably.

Of the more than fifty thousand applicants, only 1 percent—barely five hundred people—had earned the right to advance to the main event.

The organizers gathered them all in one place.

Naturally, I was among them.

"Look over there. It's Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi."

"What? That greenhorn? He looks younger than my youngest Junior Brother."

"What does age matter? Martial talent is what counts. Still, he's incredible. He's come this far after becoming the Fire King's Disciple only a year ago…"

"For fuck's sake. Is he supposed to have a Heavenly Martial Physique or something?"

I turned toward the voice. A man who looked to be in his early thirties flinched, then quietly avoided my gaze.

He must have thought I was going to say something to him, but he had read me completely wrong.

The guy's got good instincts.

The System's possibilities were endless. My Muscles and Bones, which had already been so exceptional that Jeok Cheongang called them the Heavenly Martial Physique, had developed even further during my training on Mount Jiuhua.

Eventually, even Jeok Cheongang had shaken his head again and again.

"Monster. Just how much higher do you intend to climb?"

"I should at least see how far I can go."

"If this old man had possessed even half your Muscles and Bones, there would be Two Gods in the martial world by now instead of One God."

"But you don't."

"…Add another hundred geun[1390] to the iron ball."

Acting cocky had only made me suffer more, but in the end, every bit of it had helped me immensely.

After all, hard work—no, the System—never betrayed me.

[1389] Amitabha is the Buddha associated with the Pure Land. Saying his name is a Buddhist invocation.

[1390] A *geun* is a Korean weight unit of 600 g (1.32 lb); a hundred geun is 60 kg (132 lb).

The System paid out points and EXP with perfect precision, and my basic stats were absurdly high, so any martial art I used was several times more effective.

That was how I managed to beat three of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, each among the best in their respective fields.

The Iron-Water Divine Dragon of the Yangtze River Channel League had even voluntarily withdrawn from the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

When I asked why he would go that far, he said he couldn't win as long as I was around, so he might as well hurry home.

I couldn't decide whether that made him simple or smart, but he was definitely a cool guy.

On the other hand…

"Alas, the martial world's sense of decency has fallen to the ground. How could such a frivolous and violent man gain power? Oh, heavens!"

"You bastard who'd mix rice with dog shit and eat it. Even leaving you in a cesspit for three months and ten days wouldn't satisfy me."

"This is impossible. Are you saying this Young Master's knowledge is inferior to that man's martial arts? That cannot be. I must establish a new theory of mechanisms and formations."

Those three were simply beyond saving.

I had been listening to their endless muttering from behind me when I spun around.

"Hey, you three idiots."

Their muttering stopped dead at my call.

A moment later, the three idiots snapped their heads up and expressed their anger one after another, each in his own way.

"Alas, an idiot? How vulgar."

The Daoist in spotless white robes was Baek Woo, the Kunlun Cloud Dragon. I had sent him plummeting during the third assessment by stepping on his face.

I learned later that he had severe cleanliness issues and spent two shichen[1391] showering as soon as the assessment ended.

"I'll stuff shit into your mouth, you bastard."

Unlike Baek Woo, whose mere presence suggested cleanliness, this man reeked of piss and was a beggar to the bone.

Born and raised in the Beggars' Sect, he had eventually risen to the position of Successor Beggar—the man who would one day lead the sect.

His name was Gung Gibang.

The so-called Beggar Prince, pure-blooded beggar,[1392] ultimate beggar.

[1391] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen is about four hours.

[1392] "Pure-blooded" echoes *seonggol*, the highest hereditary rank in the ancient Korean kingdom of Silla.

During the fourth assessment, Gung Gibang had grabbed me by the back of the neck and been rewarded with a punch to the solar plexus.

"Idiot? Was that directed at this Young Master? If you could explain what you intended by it—and, assuming you know the exact meaning of the word *idiot*, define it for me—I would appreciate it."

The last was Zhuge Gyun, the Divine Marvel Dragon of the Zhuge Clan.

He wore the neat clothes of a scholar and a tidy hero's headband. Judging by his clothes alone, he looked like the most sane of the three.

That was only natural, considering he was wedged between a cleanliness-obsessed Daoist who couldn't stand a single speck of dust on his clothes and a beggar who looked as though he would happily eat filth even if it splashed into his mouth.

But as I had guessed, he was no ordinary eccentric.

He had expressed considerable regret over losing in the mechanisms-and-formations assessment, the fifth one.

Just look at this lineup…

A group more stacked than Manchester United's squad under Sir Alex Ferguson.[1393]

Seeing the three of them lined up together made my breath catch and my vision go dark. I took a moment to compose myself before speaking.

"Shut your mouths, all of you. Stop chattering. You're driving me crazy."

"Alas, did you just say 'shut your mouths'? Fellow Daoist Jin Taekyung, how can every word out of your mouth be so vulgar?"

"A bastard who wouldn't feel satisfied even after being rolled up in a mat, hung from a post, and beaten with a dog cudgel for forty-five days."

"'Shut your mouths. Stop chattering…' Those are not expressions commonly used in our family. I am personally quite curious, so could you write down some of the words you often use and give me a copy?"

"…"

I wanted to beat the crap out of all three of them.

Lamenting the fact that reality wouldn't allow it, I addressed the three idiots.

"If I meet any of you in a duel, consider yourselves dead."

"…!"

"…!"

"…!"

As expected, a cudgel was the best medicine for lunatics.

The three idiots clamped their mouths shut and exchanged glances.

Then it happened.

[1393] Manchester United is an English football club. Sir Alex Ferguson managed it during a period of sustained success.

Click. Click.
The sound of something hard striking the floor pierced everyone’s ears.
An old man soon appeared on the dais, one leg fitted with a wooden prosthetic.
“Sorry I’m late. As you can see, my leg’s in this state.”
He grinned, baring yellow teeth, and introduced himself.
“Nice to meet you. I’m Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox.”

Chapter 249

The Thousand-Faced Fox. A fox with a thousand faces.

I had never seen a nickname suit someone so poorly.

Song Ho, the old man known as the Thousand-Faced Fox, was bigger than most burly men, with the warm, genial face of the grandfather next door.

He was about as far from a fox as a person could get. If anything, he seemed like the exact opposite.

He looks like that grandpa. The one who stands outside the chicken shop whether it rains or snows.[1394]

Put a pair of glasses on him, and they could have been twins.

But while I entertained such carefree thoughts, the air around me was taut as a drawn bowstring.

Faces were tense. I could hear people swallowing nervously.

The Thousand-Faced Fox…

He couldn't have gotten that nickname for nothing.

Once I changed my perspective, everything began to look different.

The aura I sensed from Song Ho was that of a Peak master—nothing more, nothing less—but there was something else about him.

Something unrelated to martial arts. Something only he possessed.

What is it?

As I studied Song Ho's profile, his head turned, and our gazes met.

He beckoned me over, so I took a step toward him.

"So you're the one?"

"Pardon?"

"Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. I've heard plenty about how the Disciple of Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, performed exceptionally well in the preliminaries."

Judging by the way he spoke, he seemed to have known Jeok Cheongang to some extent. I quickly bowed my head.

"Thank you."

"And you're also the reason there are so many more finalists in this Star-Array Grand Banquet."

I had heard plenty of things said about me, but this was a first.

I tilted my head. "Because of me?"

"Of course."

[1394] The grandfather outside the chicken shop is Colonel Sanders, whose image appears outside KFC restaurants.

A deep smile spread across Song Ho's lips.

"Aren't you the one who destroyed every mechanism and formation we installed for the final assessment?"

"Oh."

"Thanks to you, there must be a hundred more qualifiers. Once you destroyed the core, everyone else had a much easier time passing."

That happened?

Come to think of it, everyone had seemed to clear the assessment unusually quickly.

At the time, I had simply assumed the locals knew all about mechanisms and formations, unlike a foreigner like me.

"Judging by your expression, you had no idea."

"Yeah, well. I'm completely clueless when it comes to that stuff."

"Don't you regret it?"

"Regret what?"

"Destroying the core of the mechanisms and formations. There could have been far fewer competitors than there are now."

"Four hundred or five hundred—what's the difference?"

"'What's the difference,' you say…"

At my breezy answer, Song Ho pointed behind me.

"It won't be easy."

I turned in the direction of his finger.

The martial artists filling the training ground—including the three idiots—were all staring at me.

There were more than five hundred of them.

Every single one was either a Supreme First Rate martial artist recognized anywhere under heaven or a Peak master.

Some were scions of prestigious families who had learned martial arts with every possible advantage. Others were wandering martial artists whose bodies bore countless scars like medals.

That is a lot.

But it didn't matter. Four hundred, five hundred, even a thousand—my answer would remain the same.

I looked at Song Ho and slowly spoke.

"It doesn't matter. All I have to do is win."

"What? Ha! Hahaha!"

Damn, that was embarrassing now that I'd actually said it.

Song Ho must have loved my answer, because he burst into laughter. At the same time, though, I had drawn plenty of aggro.

I scratched the back of my head, which was beginning to prickle.

They're all thinking the same thing, so why pretend otherwise?

Everyone had come to the Star-Array Grand Banquet with a single goal: victory.

At this point, pretending otherwise would have been more ridiculous.

"You're an interesting young friend. Great Hero Jeok really raised quite the man."

Song Ho patted me on the shoulder and laughed with satisfaction.

Just then, a middle-aged supervisor who had been about to climb onto the dais spotted him and stopped short.

"Is that you, Sir Song? What brings you here…"

Song Ho's hand fell from my shoulder.

"I heard the qualifiers had arrived, so I stopped by to see their faces. Aren't they future pillars of the world?"

He swept a pleased gaze over the crowd, then turned away.

"Then this old relic will take his leave. It was a pleasure, everyone."

"…"

I didn't answer.

It had lasted only an instant, but I had definitely seen it.

His eyes had narrowed like those of a fox stalking its prey, his gaze suddenly razor-sharp.

The Thousand-Faced Fox.

I was beginning to understand why that genial-looking old man had been given such a nickname.

Where was he looking?

And who had he seen? What had he seen in them?

That gaze had flashed past in an instant, but it had certainly not been the gaze of a Senior surveying juniors far beneath him.

I was quickly scanning everyone's faces when—

"Hey! Friend!"

At first, I wondered what kind of lunatic was shouting.

A booming voice rang through the quiet training ground as someone waved enthusiastically.

I recognized his face from somewhere and let out a deep sigh.

What? That bastard passed too?

The Always-Victorious Sword, Jongni Chu.

The sight of his beaming smile made my curiosity vanish in an instant.

"All qualifiers, follow me."

I had no idea how long we walked behind the middle-aged supervisor before we arrived at a long line of carriages stretching into the distance.

“Wait. Where are we going?”

I didn’t know who had asked, but whoever it was must have been getting dirty looks from everyone around him.

The schedule following the preliminaries had already been explained several times.

The middle-aged supervisor answered curtly.

“Luoyang.”

The Star-Array Grand Banquet’s preliminaries had been held on Mount Song with outsiders barred from entering, but the main event would take place in Luoyang, with a different format.

I had heard that spectator stands had even been prepared so people could watch the duels.

That was probably why the main event was called the true beginning of the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

“Everyone, board the carriages. It isn’t far, so we’ll arrive soon.”

Clip-clop-clop!

The instant the carriage doors closed, the horses’ hooves pounded against the ground.

I gazed out the window at Mount Song receding into the distance.

Three days of beautiful memories…

I wish that had been the reason.

The truth was that I simply didn’t want to look at the faces of the idiots riding with me.

“It’s been a while. Have you been well?”

“Fuck off. Don’t talk to me.”

Jongni Chu started us off lightly.

But it was too soon to relax. The war had only just begun.

“Good heavens, gentlemen. Did you hear what that Fellow Daoist just said? ‘Fuck off’! What is he, some common street thug? How vulgar and undignified…”

It was Baek Woo, the Kunlun Cloud Dragon and one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

Without taking my eyes off the window, I said, “Shut your mouth. I won’t say it twice. And this ‘Fellow Daoist’ shit—I’ll turn you into cheese crust with the Flame Divine Palm.”

“What? ‘Shit’? You were speaking to this poor Daoist?”

“Yep.”

“You seem awfully high and mighty just because you happened to get ahead of me once in qinggong[1395]…”

“Hey, you.”

I turned my head and stared at Baek Woo.

“I told you to shut up.”

Our gazes collided in midair. A brief silence passed, and we both reached out at the same time.

No—Baek Woo was half a beat faster. He made the first move.

Whoosh! Rattle-rattle-rattle!

And then it was over in an instant.

Baek Woo’s eyes widened as I immobilized both his wrists.

“S-Striking Second, Hitting First?”

“Trying to get the first hit in, you bastard?”

What mattered in a fight was not who moved faster.

The result. The result was all that mattered.

I had definitely started later than Baek Woo, but I reached my target faster. That was all there was to it.

“Your grappling technique is a mess. Did you put everything into qinggong[1396]?”

“H-How did you…”

“What do you mean, how? You’re weaker than me, and I’m stronger than you.”

I grinned at his stunned face and continued.

“Now, you have three choices. Number one: take one hard hit from the Flame Divine Palm right now.”

“…”

“Judging by your expression, you don’t like that one. Number two: take a gentle hit from the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist. For reference, I brought down a cliff with it. If you think your body is tougher than a cliff, go ahead and try your luck.”

“I-Is there no third option?”

“‘Is there no’? What’s with that formal *-so* ending? You’re using haoche.[1397] Are you from the Lower District Sect? I thought you were from the Kunlun Sect.”

Baek Woo bit down hard on his lip.

“I-I am twenty-six this year. Four years older than you.”

“Oh, four years. Then would you rather take four Flame Divine Palms?”

“Gasp!”

Baek Woo shook his head vigorously.

“All right. Say it again.”

[1395] *Qinggong* refers to martial-arts movement techniques associated with speed and lightness.

[1396] *Qinggong* refers to martial-arts movement techniques associated with speed and lightness.

[1397] *Haoche* is a formal Korean speech register traditionally marked by sentence endings such as *-so*.

“Is there no third option…please?”

“There is. Number three: keep your mouth shut in front of me from now on.”

“I’ll take that one!”

“Good. Let’s travel in silence.”

I released Baek Woo’s wrists.

Conflict flickered in his eyes, but his face soon fell, and he lowered his head.

Unless he was exceptionally stupid and shameless, that was the obvious response.

That takes care of one, at least.

I looked over the others in turn.

Jongni Chu stared wide-eyed between Baek Woo and me.

Gung Gibang stopped scratching his thigh, while Zhuge Gyun closed the book he had been reading so intently.

“Hey. Beggars’ Sect.”

“…”

“Does this bastard only open his mouth when he’s talking about shit?”

Gung Gibang was the quietest of the three idiots. Whenever he did speak, it was usually some curse-like remark that began with dog shit, continued through cow shit, and ended with horse shit.

He was filthy beyond belief.

“Anyway, you get a choice too. The same three I gave him. You heard them, right?”

Gung Gibang nodded, his matted hair bobbing up and down.

“Pick quickly. I can’t be bothered waiting.”

After remaining silent for a while, Gung Gibang finally opened his mouth.

“The Beggars’ Sect’s Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms is one of the five greatest martial arts under heaven. Anyone who masters even eight-tenths of it will have few rivals in the world.”

“So?”

“Unfortunately, I have only mastered five-tenths of the Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms.”

“…?”

Gung Gibang continued, his eyes shining with determination.

“Therefore, I choose number three.”

“…”

I almost smacked him across the head, but stopped myself. Hitting him would probably only dirty my hand.

“Then keep your mouth shut from now on, Gibang. And make sure you speak politely.”

“G-Gibang? Politely?”

"Might Makes Right. Haven't you heard of it?"

"Even so, that's a bit…"

"Oh, right. You're twenty-six too, aren't you? Since you're four years older than me, would you like four Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fists?"

"…!"

The wavering light in Gung Gibang's eyes slowly settled.

He clenched his fists and shook out both hands.

Swish! Clack!

With lightning-fast movements, Gung Gibang formed a fist-and-palm salute and bowed his head.

"From now on, I shall call you Jin hyung.[1398]"

"Good."

Having neatly dealt with two of them, I turned toward the last idiot.

Zhuge Gyun had closed his book and was stroking a spotless white fan made from crane feathers.

"Galgyun."

"My surname is Zhuge. My given name is Gyun."

"Right. Galgyun. You've already chosen, haven't you?"

"Choosing is difficult."

"If you still haven't decided after watching the two Seniors in front of you, then you'll end up a corpse."

Zhuge Gyun regarded me calmly.

"My honored ancestor, Zhuge Wuhou, decided to enter public service only after Liu Bei's Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage.[1399]"

"What the hell? I told you to give me a number, and this lunatic starts talking about *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*. So what am I supposed to do?"

"Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage.[1400] Since Wuhou opened his heart after three visits, this Young Master chooses option three."

"…"

As expected of the Zhuge Clan.

Just look at that strategic buildup. He had even dragged his ancestor into it.

Maybe I should turn that crane-feather fan into a blood-feather fan.

Only one person remained, but Jongni Chu gave a sheepish laugh and raised both hands in surrender.

[1398] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[1399] "Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage" refers to Liu Bei's repeated visits to recruit Zhuge Liang as his strategist.

[1400] "Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage" refers to Liu Bei's repeated visits to recruit Zhuge Liang as his strategist.

"How frightening. I'll keep my mouth shut for the entire journey."

"Don't keep pestering me. Understood?"

"I understand. If that is what you want, so be it."

I had no particular grudge against Jongni Chu, so I decided to leave it at that.

Just as I began enjoying the peace I had won by subduing the three idiots, the speeding carriage slowed and soon came to a stop.

"We have arrived at our destination."

I looked out the window.

Lofty walls dozens of jang[1401] high. A massive iron gate. And a signboard bathed in the soft glow of sunset.

Murim Alliance

[1401] A *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 250

The Demonic Cult.

If they had never existed—if those who called themselves the Heavenly Demon Divine Cult had never appeared—the Murim under heaven would never have united as one.

But when Qinghai, Gansu, and Sichuan fell into the Demonic Cult's hands in a mere four months, everything changed.

The leaders of countless orthodox factions, including the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, gathered in one place. Even major figures from the unorthodox factions and dark-path forces, such as the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance, lent their strength.

And at the center of it all stood the Martial God.

An unparalleled master known as the greatest beneath heaven. An invincible man who belonged to no faction.

Let us raise a single flag. It is the only way.

Thus, after years of joining together and splitting apart, the orthodox factions, unorthodox factions, and dark-path forces united beneath a single flag.

The Murim Alliance was born.

Not long after the fierce ten-year Great War ended, the Murim Alliance was dissolved along with the Martial God's disappearance. But the site where the heroes of old had once gathered remained, carrying on in a new form with new people.

"Good grief, it's packed."

A middle-aged man stared wearily at the long line stretching out in front of the Murim Alliance.

They hadn't even entered yet, and it was already this crowded. Just imagining the chaos inside was enough to make his vision go dark.

To make matters worse, he still hadn't recovered from yesterday's drinking.

"Honey, why don't we just take a lap around the market and go home? Hm?"

At his desperate whisper, his wife firmly shook her head.

"No. Do you have any idea how excited he is? He's been begging us for three whole days, ever since the main event began."

"No, no. It'll be fine. We can take a lap around the market and put some candy in his mouth. That'll keep him quiet. To hell with the Star-Array Grand Banquet and all that. What's so impressive about watching Murim people fight anyway… Huh?"

The middle-aged man sucked in a startled breath.

His son, who had been asleep on his wife's back, was now awake and staring at him.

The boy's large eyes were moist, as if he might burst into tears at any moment.

"Dad. Aren't we going to see the Star-Array Grand Banquet?"

"No, son. That's not what I—"

"Sniff… Sob…"

"W-Wait. Just hear me out."

"Waaaaaaah!"

"…My boy sure has a powerful set of lungs."

A short while later, the child held candy in one hand and a wooden doll the size of an adult's palm in the other.

The unexpected expense left the middle-aged man grumbling.

"Damn thieves. How can a little chunk of wood cost that much?"

But he was still a parent. The sight of his son's beaming face eased his irritation a little.

"You like it that much?"

"Yes! Jin Taekyung is so cool! The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi is the best!"

"Jin Taekyung? The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi? Is that wooden doll's name Jin Taekyung?"

"Dad, you don't know Jin Taekyung?"

"O-Of course I do."

"Really?"

"Of course. There's nothing your dad doesn't know."

He couldn't sacrifice his dignity as a father over some wooden doll.

Having narrowly escaped the crisis, the middle-aged man waited until his son was looking away, then quietly asked his wife, "Honey. Who's Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi? You don't know either, do you?"

"Why wouldn't I?"

His wife looked at him as if he were hopeless.

"We came here to watch his duel today."

"…"

"The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. Hyeok has told you over and over that he's won three straight duels in the main event… How can a father take so little interest in his own child?"

As his wife continued lecturing him, the middle-aged man had only one thought.

I hope this Sleeping Dragon or whatever gets his ass kicked today.

Whoosh!

I calmly watched the sword sweep toward me.

Fast as an arrow, agile as a snake.

After a bewildering series of forms, red Sword Energy shot toward me.

Shhk-shhk-shhk-shhk!

I flipped through the air. The Sword Energy passed less than half a span[1402] from me, and I thrust out my fist.

One punch wreathed in blue flame—the first form of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Boom!

A powerful collision.

Sword Energy and Fist Energy crashed together, sending a thunderous boom across the arena. Stone dust from the dueling platform billowed up, blocking my view.

I stepped forward.

Again. One more time.

Boom! Kraa-boom!

The shock wave bursting from my fist split the air. The flames of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist devoured the cloud of dust.

Beyond it stood a man.

Blood trickled from the corner of his mouth, his face deathly pale. He clutched a broken sword and stared at me with wide eyes.

“H-How?”

“Well.”

The moment I answered, I kicked off the ground.

Crack.

As my foot left the ground, spiderweb cracks spread across the solid bluestone. I tore through the fierce wind and threw a third punch at him.

“I surrender!”

The words burst from him like a scream.

My fist stopped directly in front of his nose. The pressure from its tremendous speed and force sent his hair whipping back.

The hero’s headband slipped from his forehead, fluttered out of the arena, and landed with a thud.

“S-Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, victory!”

Waaaaah!

At the referee’s declaration, the cheers the crowd had been holding back erupted from every direction.

[1402] A *ppyeom* is a hand span, measured between the outstretched thumb and little finger. Half a span is roughly 10 cm (4 in), though the length varies by person.

Hundreds—thousands—of spectators surged to their feet, throwing flowers and all manner of objects.

“Yeah! Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!”

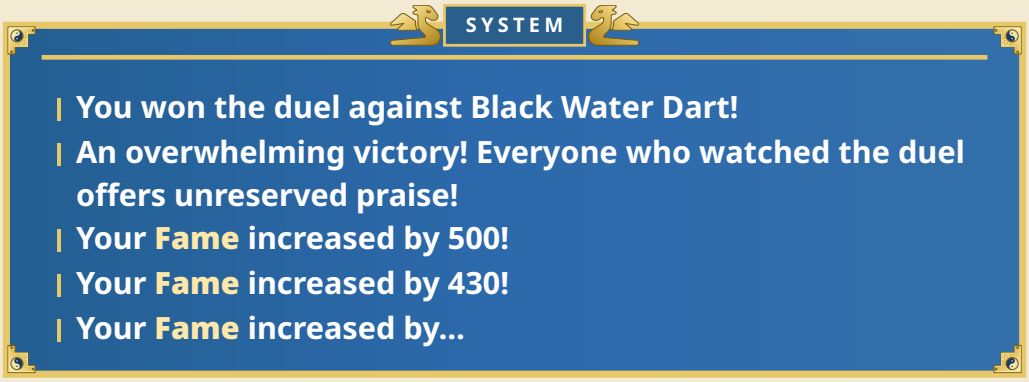
“Dad! I can’t see! Put me on your shoulders!”

“You’re the best, you punk! I even bought your wooden doll!”

The stands weren’t filled with martial artists alone. Plenty of ordinary people had come from Henan and even farther away to see the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

I waved to one particularly noisy father and son, then turned away.

Ding.



I listened to the familiar notifications as I stepped down from the dueling platform. At the same moment, someone landed lightly in front of me using an elegant movement technique.

Tap!

“Good heavens, what are all these specks of dust on your precious body? This poor Daoist[1403] will wipe them away for you.”

Damn it. This bastard’s here again.

No matter how many times I told him not to come, he refused to fucking listen. There was no helping him.

I snatched the towel from his hand.

“If you’re going to come, at least walk over like a normal person. Stop using the Cloud-Dragon Eight Forms or Oh Tae-sik or whatever.”

Baek Woo, the Kunlun Cloud Dragon, answered glumly.

“It is the Cloud-Dragon Eight Forms. Even so, it is one of the Kunlun Sect’s secret arts. You could at least remember its name…”

“Right. Imagine how heartbroken your Master would be if he saw you using that secret art to deliver towels. He’s probably watching from the VIP seats right now.”

“My Master told me to get along with Fellow Daoist.[1404]”

[1403] A Daoist is a follower of Daoism. “Fellow Daoist” is an address for another practitioner; “this poor Daoist” is a self-effacing way to refer to oneself.

[1404] A Daoist is a follower of Daoism. “Fellow Daoist” is an address for another practitioner; “this poor Daoist” is a self-effacing way to refer to oneself.

"…"

"I heard Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, once saved my Master's life…"

No wonder Baek Woo had been so unusually friendly since the day after we arrived.

He must have scampered over to his Master to tattle on me, only to have the whole thing blow up in his face.

Then there were my last three duels—or four, counting the one just now. Watching them must have driven one fact home.

I was far stronger than he was.

The same went for the other two idiots.

"Our sect's Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms is one of the five greatest palm arts beneath heaven."

"Sure. But you've only mastered it to the fifth level, right?"

"That is correct."

"Is that why you brought that?"

"Yes."

Gung Gibang approached with a solemn expression, carrying a basin of water for me to wash my face.

"…"

The whole thing was absurd, but I thanked him, washed my face, and dried it with the towel Baek Woo had brought.

The Beggars' Sect's Successor Beggar had brought me water, and the Kunlun Cloud Dragon, one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, had brought me a towel.

To everyone else, this must have looked like a very strange sight.

Wait.

Come to think of it, one of them was missing.

"Where's Galgyun?"

Normally, he would have rushed over by now and started rambling about his ancestor, Zhuge Wuhou,[1405] but he was nowhere to be seen.

Baek Woo answered, "Young Master Zhuge went to fight his duel."

"No wonder he's not here."

There were no fewer than five hundred competitors in the main event, so the duels were held in sequence across several different arenas.

Today was the third day. Once all the scheduled duels ended, only around thirty competitors would remain.

There have been more injuries than I expected.

Every participant was a master with at least one remarkable skill.

[1405] *Wuhou* is an honorific title of Zhuge Liang, a statesman and strategist of China's Three Kingdoms period.

Injuries were unavoidable. Some people even won a razor-close duel only to withdraw afterward.

I'm the unusual one.

Counting the victory I had just secured, I had won four duels, and not one had lasted more than fifteen minutes.

The longest had gone for a little over two hundred exchanges, and only because I'd wanted to experience my opponent's unusual martial art.

I'm glad I entered the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

From what I had seen, some of the competitors possessed a deeper understanding of particular martial arts than I did.

I was simply far superior in several other respects, and facing unfamiliar martial arts I had never encountered before was giving me valuable experience.

I never would've gained this kind of experience if I'd stayed in Fire Gate Cavern.

My gaze naturally drifted toward the VIP seats.

Jeok Cheongang was trying his hardest to control his expression, while Jin Wikyung looked so delighted he could barely contain himself.

And beside them…

"That old man's here again today."

"Who?"

"Who?"

"The Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho. He hasn't missed a single day."

Baek Woo and Gung Gibang started to turn, then froze.

"Why? Is he that important?"

"Sir Song?"

"You mean the Thousand-Faced Fox?"

They both asked at once, then lowered their voices.

"He is certainly an impressive man. No—perhaps frightening would be more accurate."

"The Murim Alliance's Hidden Shadow Pavilion once possessed an intelligence network that rivaled the Beggars' Sect's. It may even have surpassed ours."

"The Hidden Shadow Pavilion?"

Gung Gibang nodded.

"I heard it performed truly astonishing feats during the Great Faction War. Of course, the Thousand-Faced Fox, who was its head, deserves much of the credit for the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's existence."

So in modern terms, was he something like the director of the FBI?

If even the Beggars' Sect's Successor Beggar spoke of it that way, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's intelligence network must have been extraordinary.

Judging from the past tense, it had probably followed the Murim Alliance into dissolution.

The former head of a retired intelligence organization…

As I watched him closely, Song Ho rose from his seat and disappeared somewhere.

I followed his retreating figure with my eyes until it vanished. Then a roar from the crowd rang in my ears.

“Waaaaah!”

“The Life-Sustaining Sword won again!”

I turned toward the cheers and saw Jongni Chu descending from a dueling platform, his clothes reduced to rags.

His entire body glistened with sweat, and he was gasping for breath.

The two idiots muttered as they watched him.

“Life-Sustaining Sword? Whoever came up with that epithet certainly has a way with names.”

“He does keep scraping out victories by a hair. In that sense, the Always-Victorious Sword truly is always victorious.”

The nickname Life-Sustaining Sword had been given to Jongni Chu because he won every match by barely surviving.

Even I hadn’t expected Jongni Chu to reach four wins, but apparently he was stronger in a real fight than I’d thought.

If he’s made it this far, he must have some skill.

Just how did he fight to earn a name like Life-Sustaining Sword?

A quiet laugh escaped me as I watched Jongni Chu frantically gulp down cold water.

Maybe I’ll meet him on the dueling platform later.

I hadn’t had much contact with Jongni Chu since three days ago. We merely acknowledged each other whenever we happened to cross paths.

If our next meeting was on the dueling platform, I might end up feeling a little sorry for him.

“Anyway, thanks for the towel and the water. You can clean these up while you’re at it.”

Baek Woo and Gung Gibang took the towel and basin respectively, then asked, “Where are you going?”

“Our sect’s Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms is one of the most renowned martial arts beneath heaven… Where are you going?”

“To watch Gyun’s duel.”

I had heard Zhuge Gyun practiced an unusual fan technique using a folding fan. I figured I might as well watch his duel and broaden my knowledge of martial arts.

I was about to head toward another dueling platform when I suddenly stopped.

“Oh, right. Who did they say his opponent was?”

The Invincible Divine Sword.

Zhuge Gyun gasped for breath.

When he had first heard his opponent’s epithet, he had laughed inwardly. It was far too grand a name for some unknown nobody with no reputation.

But…

How has someone like this remained unknown until now?

The hand gripping his fan trembled.

His legs had already lost half their strength, and merely staying upright was becoming difficult. His eyes ached from straining to follow sword strikes that moved too quickly to see.

The internal energy in his dantian had run dry long ago.

Zhuge Gyun was one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, yet he had been reduced to this state while the Invincible Divine Sword remained utterly at ease.

No—he even seemed excited.

“Wow! You’re the first person I’ve ever seen use a fan technique! Do you have another one? Another one?”

“…”

At the innocent voice drifting from beneath the deeply lowered bamboo hat, Zhuge Gyun threw away his fan.

Chapter 251

My prediction that Zhuge Gyun would win turned out to be spectacularly wrong.

By the time we reached the area where his duel and several others were being held, the crowd was roaring the Invincible Divine Sword's name while Zhuge Gyun sat there in a daze.

"What happened? You lost?"

Zhuge Gyun gave a bitter nod.

"I was completely toyed with. I couldn't touch so much as a hair on his head."

Zhuge Gyun was a direct descendant of the Zhuge Clan, one of the Five Great Families.

As his epithet, the Divine Marvel Dragon, suggested, his true weapon was his brilliant mind. But he had also learned his family's secret arts and was an exceptional martial artist in his own right.

Intelligence alone wasn't enough to earn a place among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

And someone toyed with him?

Then his opponent was clearly a league or two above him.

My curiosity piqued, I asked Zhuge Gyun, "Where is he?"

"He probably left right after the duel… Huh? There he is."

I followed Zhuge Gyun's finger and narrowed my eyes.

"That guy? The one stuffing his face with dumplings?"

"Yes."

"…Hmm."

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing. There's just something familiar about him."

He wore a baggy robe and a bamboo hat pulled low over his face. I couldn't make out his features or even his build, but there was something strangely familiar about the sight of him shoveling dumplings into his mouth.

Where have I seen him before?

At times like this, the direct approach was best. I headed toward the Invincible Divine Sword.

The closer I got, the less certain I became that I recognized him. But I did realize one thing.

He's strong.

His posture was full of openings, and he looked so carefree that he didn't seem remotely on guard.

Yet the energy I sensed from the Invincible Divine Sword was in no way inferior to mine.

Was there always someone like this around?

After a moment's thought, I spoke.

"Excuse me."

Chomp, chomp.

The Invincible Divine Sword's mouth stopped in the middle of devouring dumplings as if possessed.

"You're the Invincible Divine Sword, correct?"

"…"

"Sorry to bother you when we've never met, but I have something I'd like to ask."

"…"

"Excuse me?"

What was wrong with this guy? Why wasn't he answering when I was talking to him?

As I stared, the Invincible Divine Sword's Adam's apple bobbed beneath his bamboo hat.

Gulp.

"Ahem. Ahem."

"…?"

"Ahem. J-Just a moment."

After clearing his throat several times, he spoke in a low baritone.

But how should I put it? The voice was painfully forced.

"Why? No—I mean, what is it?"

"I have something I'd like to ask."

"Please go ahead. No—speak."

"…"

What the hell was this guy doing?

I regarded the Invincible Divine Sword through narrowed eyes. Perhaps sensing my suspicion, he tugged his bamboo hat even lower.

I'm starting to get a feeling about this.

I casually tossed out some bait.

"Oh, I should've introduced myself first. I'm Park Taekyung of the Taiyuan Park Family."

"Huh? When did you change your surname?"

"…"

"…!"

An icy silence fell.

Realizing his mistake, the Invincible Divine Sword frantically waved his hands. Instead of the forced baritone, a clear, youthful voice spilled out in a rush.

“No, that’s not what I meant. The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi is so famous that I already knew who you were.”

“Oh. I see.”

“Yes. Yes.”

“May I ask your name?”

“The Invincible Divine Sword.”

“Your name, not your epithet.”

“K-Kang Pung.”

What kind of Pung?

What a talent for names.

I let out a quiet laugh of disbelief.

There was no need to confirm it with the Qi Sense Skill. At this point, it would have been stranger if I still hadn’t figured it out.

“It’s been a while. Let’s talk somewhere quiet.”

“W-Why? I’ve never met you before.”

“Really? Then should I send a messenger pigeon to Huashan?”

“…!”

The Invincible Divine Sword slowly raised his bamboo hat.

A young man with an innocent face looked at me, resignation and delight mingling in his eyes.

“Hello, Benefactor.”

It was a welcome face I hadn’t seen in a year.

Laughing, I flicked the brim of Cheongpung’s bamboo hat.

The Murim Alliance was practically a city unto itself. It had residential areas, along with every facility needed for daily life.

So it wasn’t particularly surprising that it had an entertainment district as well.

We settled into an inn tucked away in the most secluded alley we could find.

Other than the ancient, nearly deaf proprietor, there wasn’t another customer in sight.

“I heard what happened. You ran away on the way back to Huashan?”

“Yes. Right after Benefactor left with Grandpa Jeok.”

“Why? Huashan is practically your home.”

“I didn’t want to go back. Grandpa wasn’t there anymore, and I hadn’t seen much of the world.”

“Still, I’m surprised you managed to escape.”

“My Martial Nephews tried to stop me, so I used a little force. They probably wouldn’t have woken up for three days. I ran away while they were out. Hehe.”

“…”

Just how much force had he used?

Still, only someone like Cheongpung could have pulled that off.

Baek Museong might be known as Huashan’s Lone Crane and one of the Three Plum Blossom Elites, but Cheongpung was a true genius on an entirely different level.

Even a Third Rate sword technique like the Three-Talent Sword Technique became a Peak martial art when performed by him.

From what I had seen, no one could match the depth of his understanding or the speed at which he learned martial arts.

If there were another genius like him, it would probably be Jin Mukyung.

Lost in thought, I listened to Cheongpung’s excited account of his travels through the martial world.

I had expected as much, and sure enough, he hadn’t done a damn bit of martial arts training. His stories were all about roaming around, goofing off, and eating to his heart’s content.

“I ate dumplings in Sichuan, but they were spicy!”

“Ah, yes. How astonishing.”

“Dumplings in Guangdong and Hainan have seafood in them!”

“That makes sense. They’re near the sea.”

“Dumplings in Zhejiang Province…”

Had this bastard done nothing but eat dumplings all year?

By the time he started talking about dumplings in Hunan Province, I couldn’t take it anymore and cut him off.

“So what are you going to do now?”

“About what?”

“The Invincible Divine Sword. Are you going to keep this up?”

“Yes. Martial Nephew Baek Museong knows I’m participating in the Star-Array Grand Banquet. If I disguise myself like this, no one will recognize me!”

“…”

“Hehe. I’ve fooled everyone completely.”

I would have bet my right hand and my entire fortune that they had already found him out. I was even willing to double down.

No wonder there were so many Huashan disciples near the dueling platform earlier.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet was open to martial artists from across the world, so there were no real restrictions against hiding one’s identity.

But Huashan was one of the Nine Sects and One Gang. There was no question its disciples had noticed Cheongpung long ago.

And yet they were merely watching him from a distance.

At this point, this is basically a group hidden-camera prank.

They could make a whole movie out of it and call it *The Cheongpung Show*.

I clicked my tongue inwardly as I watched Cheongpung enjoying himself. Then a thought occurred to me.

“Then I guess we’ll meet later?”

The smile on Cheongpung’s face widened.

“I hope so.”

“You hope so?”

“Yes. I was curious how strong Benefactor had become. I’ve wanted to spar with you at least once.”

The feeling was mutual.

Cheongpung and Jin Mukyung were two of the reasons I had decided to participate in the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

“What do you think, now that you’ve seen me again?”

“Hmm…”

“Be honest.”

I leaned back against the old chair.

Amid the creaking sounds, Cheongpung was silent for a moment. Then he suddenly tapped the scabbard hanging from his waist.

“Grandpa used to say that martial artists should speak with their weapons.”

“He was right.”

Straight from the Sword Saint himself.

I let out a quiet laugh and rose from my seat.

“Where are you going, Benefactor?”

“To prepare for the finals. We’ll finish our conversation there. With our respective martial arts, of course.”

“The finals…”

Cheongpung slowly repeated the word, then nodded with an unusually serious expression.

“Good. I’m going to win anyway.”

“Big talk from someone who spent the entire year eating dumplings.”

“I trained sometimes too.”

“Sure you did.”

Ignoring Cheongpung’s disgruntled muttering, I paid the bill and left the inn.

As soon as we emerged from the narrow, dark alley, we ran into a familiar face.

"Jongni Chu?"

Jongni Chu smiled and waved.

"Oh, we meet again. It seems we must be bound by fate."

"What fate? It's probably just a coincidence. What are you doing here?"

"I came to grab a bite."

"Here?"

The secluded alley held only a few shops lined up beside one another. Even those looked so old they were on the verge of collapsing.

It didn't look like a good place to find a meal by anyone's standards.

But Jongni Chu nodded calmly.

"I had some thin noodles at a nearby street stall, and the vendor told me that shop's dumplings were exceptionally good."

By sheer coincidence, he was pointing at the sign of the very inn Cheongpung and I had just left.

"Really?"

"Of course. Apparently, it's a hidden gem known only to a select few. Have you tried it?"

Cheongpung, who had already pulled his bamboo hat low over his face, abruptly joined in with his awkwardly altered voice.

"They're incredibly delicious. No, I mean, delicious they are."

Jongni Chu turned toward Cheongpung.

"I don't believe we've met. Would it be rude of me to ask who you are?"

"The Invincible Divine Sword, Kang Pung."

"Now that is an impressive epithet. I'm Jongni Chu, the Always-Victorious Sword. I hope we'll get along, friend."

"F-Friend?"

Cheongpung raised his bamboo hat slightly and stared at Jongni Chu before nodding furiously.

"Great! No—I mean, good! I'm delighted! You're the first person who's ever asked to be my friend!"

"…Enough. That's more than enough."

Why didn't he just walk around with *Cheongpung of Huashan* written across his forehead?

Jongni Chu smiled gently as he watched Cheongpung bouncing with joy while I tried to calm him down.

"It seems you already have a good friend at your side. In any case, I'll see you next time, friends."

"Yeah, let's just happen to run into each other once in a while. Not too often."

"Farewell! Farewell, my friend!"

“I’ll keep that in mind.”

He dipped his head and disappeared into the dark alley.

Once we stepped onto the bright, sunlit street, Cheongpung grinned.

“He seems like a good person. I can just tell.”

I offered him some serious advice.

“Not everyone who likes dumplings is a good person.”

“Oh, I should have told him to dip them in only a little soy sauce.”

“…”

He really didn’t listen to a word I said.

Cheongpung’s concern proved unnecessary.

Jongni Chu never entered the inn.

His steps didn’t stop even after he passed it.

How long had he walked through the dark alleys tangled together like a maze? At last, in a place containing nothing but a few rats and filth, Jongni Chu stopped.

A quiet voice slipped from his lips.

“The Invincible Divine Sword. The more I think about it, the better that epithet sounds. What do you think?”

The moment he finished speaking, the silent alley erupted into motion.

Swish, swish, swish! Pak!

Three streaks of light shot toward Jongni Chu’s vital points.

At the same time, a small masked figure shot into the air. His steps as he ran along the wall were swift and stealthy as the wind.

His qinggong[1406] was exceptional, and his concealment technique surpassed even that. Just as the masked man gathered his strength to leap—

Thud.

“Where are you going in such a hurry?”

“…!”

“Come down. Let’s talk.”

An immense force pressed down on both his shoulders. Breath brushed the back of his neck.

The masked man’s plummeting body trembled as if struck by lightning.

How can this be?!

He had completed hundreds of missions, but never once had anything like this happened.

Overwhelming. Irresistible.

[1406] *Qinggong* is a martial arts technique for moving swiftly and lightly, often across difficult terrain.

Never had those words felt so real. He realized that only one path remained to him.

Pavilion Master, it seems this is as far as I go.

The face of the superior he had loyally served for decades—the Thousand-Faced Fox—flashed before his eyes.

Just as Shadow Killer—the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's finest agent, whose name had since been forgotten—was about to bite down on the poison pellet hidden in his tooth—

"As expected of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion. Not a moment's hesitation. But…"

Tap, tap.

Lightning-fast fingers struck Shadow Killer's entire body. A low voice burrowed into his ears as his body stiffened.

"You should have known who you were following."

Consumed by utter despair, Shadow Killer felt his consciousness plunge into the abyss.

Chapter 252

One day, two days, three days.

As time passed, the tournament bracket steadily shrank. More than five hundred participants had entered the main event on its first day. Now barely ten remained.

And as the crowd's excitement rose with each passing day, one man's spirits soared with it.

"This old man has been giving it some thought…"

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, continued in a solemn voice.

"I'm beginning to think our sect's martial arts truly are the greatest under heaven. What does everyone think?"

"…"

The people in the seats of honor struggled to keep their faces from twisting.

This was hardly anything new, and they had all expected it. That did not make it sting any less.

What made it even more infuriating was that they could not refute him.

Their inability to risk offending the Fire King was one thing. More importantly, the performance of his disciple, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, had been nothing short of astonishing.

He had caused a tremendous stir from the preliminaries onward, then continued advancing triumphantly while displaying overwhelming skill against one renowned master after another.

Yesterday, he had even beaten the Hebei Peng Family's Hunyun Saber as mercilessly as a dog marked for slaughter.[1407]

Damn old man. He couldn't even wait before bragging again.

The greatest martial arts under heaven, my ass. All he did was raise one talented brat.

Still, the kid's the real deal. Where did he find such a monster?

Their thoughts were written plainly across their faces. Under normal circumstances, Jeok Cheongang would have threatened them for failing to control their expressions.

But right now, he was the very image of a benevolent Buddha.

He smiled contentedly as he looked around, then his gaze stopped on one man.

"Hey, Virility Saber King."

"…"

The enormous old man, the Thunderbolt Saber King, pretended not to hear and stared toward a distant mountain. His face had turned bright red.

[1407] The Korean comparison refers to Boknal, the hottest days of summer, traditionally associated with eating dog meat.

“When someone calls you, you should answer. I’m three years older than you, too. Isn’t that right?”

“…Shut your mouth while I’m still asking nicely.”

“Oh, come now. Why are you so angry?”

Jeok Cheongang responded slyly, widening his eyes in feigned surprise.

“Is it because that eldest grandson of yours—the one you praised until your mouth went dry, calling him the greatest prodigy in Hebei or whatever—spent fifteen minutes getting beaten by my disciple?”

“…!”

“Good grief. Haven’t you heard that victory and defeat are simply part of war? Why get so worked up over it?”

Only then did the Thunderbolt Saber King, who had been snorting furiously, slowly turn his gaze toward Jeok Cheongang.

“Th-That’s right. Sometimes you win, and sometimes you lose.”

“Exactly. That’s how it goes at that age.”

“You’re finally saying something sensible. Since we’re on the subject, my grandson was exhausted from such a long journey. That’s why he couldn’t display his full strength.”

Jeok Cheongang smiled kindly and nodded.

“I understand. When someone’s skill is lacking, he needs an excuse.”

“…What did you say?”

“Come to think of it, they aren’t even the same age. Your eldest grandson is over thirty, isn’t he? Our Taekyung is only twenty-two. Heh heh. It can happen. It can.”

“Y-You damned old bastard!”

“Hm? What was that? I can’t hear you very well. You’re the Grand Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family who was eliminated in the quarterfinals, after all. Hahahaha!”

The Thunderbolt Saber King’s eyes rolled back as he started to surge to his feet.

A hand holding a string of prayer beads blocked him.

The Dharma King, Hong Dao, sighed as he looked at the two men.

“Amitabha.[1408] The two of you should act your age. Have you forgotten where you are?”

This was the dueling arena of the Star-Array Grand Banquet, with thousands upon thousands of spectators watching.

Only then did the Thunderbolt Saber King notice all the curious gazes directed toward the seats of honor. He lowered himself back into his seat.

“Urgh.”

[1408] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha invoked in Buddhist prayer.

“Benefactor Jeok, what about you?”

Jeok Cheongang stared at Hong Dao for a moment, then gave a small nod.

“…Fine. I understand.”

“Good. Everyone should get along. What will you do when I’m no longer here?”

“What do you think? I’ll break that old man’s nose.”

Despite the Thunderbolt Saber King’s taunt, Jeok Cheongang did not react.

After glancing sidelong at Hong Dao, he merely stared toward the dueling arena with a heavy expression.

Something Hong Dao had said before continued to echo in his mind.

I intend to step down after this Star-Array Grand Banquet.

His old friend was preparing for death.

Had he said he had a year left at most? Hong Dao could no longer read the heavenly patterns as clearly as before, but if the Dharma King said it was so, then it was so.

Damn bald monk. You should live another ten years at least.

No matter how high Jin Taekyung’s victories lifted his spirits, thoughts of Hong Dao soon weighed them down again.

Just as they were now.

Sensing the change in Jeok Cheongang’s mood, Hong Dao suddenly spoke.

“In any case, there have been an unusual number of upsets at this Star-Array Grand Banquet. Wouldn’t you agree?”

“The Abbot is right.”

“None of us expected these results.”

The Sect Leaders in the seats of honor nodded.

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi goes without saying…”

At the mention of Jin Taekyung, the muscles in Jin Wikyung’s face twitched from his seat at the lower end of the table.

He remained silent only because he still lacked the age and standing in the martial world to speak freely among those present. Given the chance, he would have leaped to his feet and danced for joy long ago.

The Sect Leaders looked at him with undisguised envy as they continued.

“But the most unexpected upsets were the Life-Sustaining Sword—or rather, the Always-Victorious Sword—and the Invincible Divine Sword.”

“Ah, yes. Those two surprised me the most as well.”

What kind of place was the Star-Array Grand Banquet?

It was a gathering attended by countless young, renowned martial artists from every corner of the world.

Yet the Always-Victorious Sword and the Invincible Divine Sword were not disciples of any famous major sect, nor had either of them ever made a name for themselves.

That they still remained in the bracket was even more surprising than Jin Taekyung's advancement. After all, Taekyung was both the Fire King's disciple and a member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

"The Invincible Divine Sword is particularly impressive. He seems capable of holding his own against even an Elder of our sect."

At the words of one of the Sect Leaders from a mid-sized sect, Jeok Cheongang, who had been quietly listening, suddenly spoke.

"Keep your mouth shut. At least then you might pass for average."

"…Excuse me?"

"I don't know what sect you belong to or who you are, but that child is already far beyond the level of a young prodigy. Are you truly unable to guess, or are you pretending not to know even though you do?"

Hong Dao and the Thunderbolt Saber King also chuckled in agreement.

"Benefactor Jeok's words are harsh, but he is right."

"I hate agreeing with that old man, but he's right. Perhaps that's only natural. He is the Sword… Ahem. In any case, the kid is incredible."

The Thunderbolt Saber King abruptly trailed off and glanced sidelong at someone.

It was a middle-aged man with a gentle smile—the Sect Leader of Huashan, the Heavenly Sword True Person.[1409]

"Hahaha. As expected, there is no deceiving the eyes of my esteemed seniors."

At the Heavenly Sword True Person's ringing laughter, the others asked suspiciously,

"Could it be…?"

"That's right. The Invincible Divine Sword is a disciple of our sect."

"Ah, I knew it!"

"You have an outstanding disciple, True Person."

A few of the stronger martial artists nodded silently, as though they had already guessed. Others exclaimed in astonishment.

But an even more shocking statement soon passed the Heavenly Sword True Person's lips.

"Not my disciple. He is my junior brother."

"Th-Then you mean…"

"By a twist of fate, we came to serve the same master. The last time I saw him was more than ten years ago… It pleases me to see how splendidly he has grown."

The same master.

[1409] "True Person," or *zhenren*, is a Daoist honorific for someone regarded as spiritually accomplished.

No one properly heard what followed. Not a single person present was unaware that the Heavenly Sword True Person's master was the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak.

The Invincible Divine Sword is the Sword Saint's disciple?

As the people around him were swept up in shock, the Heavenly Sword True Person merely smiled in silence.

He looked like a Daoist who had attained enlightenment.

His thoughts, however, were another matter entirely.

I finally caught you, you little punk!

First his master, the Sword Saint, had run away. Then his youngest junior brother had done the same.

A year ago, the Heavenly Sword True Person had thought he had finally caught up with the boy, only for Cheongpung to beat down his disciples and flee again.

Every time the Invincible Divine Sword stepped onto the dueling platform, he had to suppress the urge to grab the boy by the collar and drag him back to Huashan.

"Heh heh heh. He is a treasure of our Huashan."

The Heavenly Sword True Person hid his true feelings behind the smile of an immortal. Congratulations poured toward him.

"What a joyous occasion. The Sword Saint's name will remain in Huashan for another generation."

"Congratulations, True Person."

"My congratulations!"

"A duel between the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi and the Invincible Divine Sword… This makes the finals even more exciting. Hahaha!"

Amid the warm atmosphere, Jeok Cheongang's brow furrowed.

At the same time, a strand of Sound Transmission reached Hong Dao's ear.

—Everyone is forgetting one person.

Hong Dao quietly rolled his prayer beads.

—You mean Jongni Chu, the Always-Victorious Sword?

—That's right. Him.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet was a gathering of the martial world where anyone could participate regardless of background or affiliation. As a result, participants did not have to undergo a particularly detailed verification process before applying.

But that was only how things looked from the outside.

—I mobilized the Hidden Shadow Pavilion to investigate the identities of every participant who advanced to the main event.

A year ago, when Hong Dao first sensed the existence of Dark Heaven, the first person he sought out was the Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho.

After hearing the circumstances, Song Ho summoned his former subordinates without hesitation. Thus, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, which had been reduced to little more than a name, was reborn.

—And the result?

—The result remained the same no matter how many times we checked. Everyone's identity was confirmed except for one. We could find no trace of the Always-Victorious Sword, Jongni Chu, anywhere.

—Are you certain? If he had thoroughly concealed his identity for some reason…

—It was only a suspicion—until we lost contact with Shadow Killer three days ago.

—Shadow Killer? You mean someone got to him?

Shadow Killer was extraordinary enough that even Jeok Cheongang knew of him.

He was the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's finest intelligence agent, as well as an assassin who had reached the Supreme Peak.

It was not difficult to imagine Shadow Killer as a cold corpse by now.

—What do you think? Can you identify Jongni Chu's martial arts?

Hong Dao's Sound Transmission caused Jeok Cheongang's gaze to deepen.

—I don't know either. In fact, that is the greatest mystery.

He had encountered countless martial arts throughout his life.

He had witnessed them with his own eyes, faced them himself, and defeated them.

But the martial arts Jongni Chu displayed were utterly unfamiliar to him.

—His martial arts don't even seem particularly powerful…and yet he has somehow won every time and made it this far. They are unlike anything I have ever seen.

—Then are you saying his martial arts defy common principles?

—Defy common principles?

Jeok Cheongang's face hardened.

Decades ago, saying that something defied common principles meant only one thing.

The Demonic Path!

At the same time, the same word crossed both men's minds.

Hong Dao and Jeok Cheongang had lived through an age of war. They understood its meaning better than anyone.

—Then are you saying he is a descendant of the Demonic Cult?

—I don't know. Dark Heaven, the Demonic Cult… He may belong to either one, or perhaps to something else entirely.

Just as the two men ended their Sound Transmission with grim expressions, a shout infused with internal energy shook the dueling arena.

“Fellow martial artists, allow me to introduce the rising young master known as the Invincible Divine Sword—and Wudang’s Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon!”

The Invincible Divine Sword—or rather, Cheongpung—looked especially excited as he climbed onto the dueling platform.

As thunderous cheers poured down on him, he hopped up and down in place and waved.

“Wow! Woooow! Hello! This is my first time reaching the quarterfinals of the Star-Array Grand Banquet!”

His opponent, the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon, was warming up with a stiff expression.

He was one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, the finest young prodigies of orthodox Murim. Along with Jin Mukyung, he was said to stand at the very top.

He’s definitely strong.

He was already over thirty and the direct disciple of Wudang’s Sect Leader.

According to Zhuge Gyun, he had accumulated considerable real-world combat experience while traveling from place to place for duels.

But still…

Well, you never know how a duel will turn out.

I leaned back comfortably in the spectator stands.

Only yesterday, I had crushed the Lesser Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family as Jeok Cheongang had wished and advanced to the semifinals.

Barring a major upset, I should make it to the finals without much trouble.

And my opponent there would probably be Cheongpung.

Let’s see what you can do.

At the same moment my eyes began to shine, the flag signaling the start of the duel rose.

Chapter 253

Swish!

There was no opening stance or anything of the sort. The instant the flag signaling the start of the duel rose, the two combatants charged at each other.

As the distance of roughly ten zhang[1410] closed in a flash, a dazzling beam of light erupted from the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon's waist.

Sword Energy right from the start?

Everything had its advantages and disadvantages.

Sword Energy was tremendously powerful, but it consumed an enormous amount of internal energy.

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon had chosen a swift victory over a drawn-out battle.

Whoosh!

Blue energy streamed from his Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword and slashed down toward Cheongpung's shoulder.

A clean strike, stripped of all wasted motion. He had probably followed that same trajectory countless times since the day he first picked up a sword.

But…

If I can see it, Cheongpung can see it too.

Boom!

Half a step. That was all it took for Cheongpung to evade. The Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword, wreathed in blue Sword Energy, slammed into the dueling platform.

But the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon was an experienced Peak master. As though he had anticipated the dodge, he twisted his sword and swept it toward Cheongpung's ankle.

"Oops!"

Swish! Swish-swish-swish!

Cheongpung twisted away from the sword with a playful cry.

The Sword Energy raked and split the air in every direction like the claws of a wild beast. The loose hem of his robe caught in its path was shredded into tatters and scattered through the air.

Screams and gasps rose from the crowd.

"Eek!"

"Gasp!"

But I could see clearly. Cheongpung didn't have so much as a scratch on him, and a smile played across his lips.

[1410] A zhang (Korean jang) is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten zhang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

He was enjoying himself. Dancing lightly out of the sword strikes, Cheongpung broke into a broad grin and clapped.

“Wow! That was the Great Clarity Sword Technique, right?”

“Y-Yes.”

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon answered reflexively, his face blank with bewilderment.

And who could blame him? Anyone would have reacted the same way. *What was that? How did that bastard dodge?* His mind had to be overflowing with questions.

“The sword path is really interesting. Have you perhaps not learned the Taiji Wisdom Sword?”

“Why would you ask that…?”

“I’ve always wanted to see it. My grandfa—no, someone I know praised it several times. He said it was an excellent martial art.”

The Taiji Wisdom Sword was Wudang’s greatest secret art, famous enough that even I had heard of it a few times.

Cheongpung had spoken with pure intentions, but to anyone unfamiliar with his personality, his words were unbearably rude.

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon standing before him was no exception.

“Our sect’s martial arts exist neither to be judged by you nor to entertain you.”

His expression stiff, the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon raised his Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword and pointed it at Cheongpung.

“But if you desire it so badly, I will show you just how fearsome it is.”

A gentle yet powerful aura arose and bore down on their surroundings. At the same time, the tip of his sword moved slowly, tracing a circle.

Taiji.[1411]

The essence of Wudang’s martial arts was about to unfold in his hands.

“The Taiji Wisdom Sword! It’s the Taiji Wisdom Sword!”

“Give this everything you have. Otherwise, you will regret it.”

Whoosh!

The moment he finished speaking, the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon vanished like a phantom.

The next moment, blue Sword Energy rippled through the air and aimed at Cheongpung’s upper body.

That was when Cheongpung’s sword, which had remained sheathed throughout the duel, finally appeared.

Screeeech—boom!

[1411] Taiji is a Chinese concept associated with the interplay of yin and yang.

Sword Energy collided with Sword Energy. It was only a single clash, but who held the advantage was obvious.

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon skidded back a full zhang, his eyes wide. Blood flowed from his torn hand.

“W-What is this?”

“Can I go this time?”

With that question, Cheongpung’s figure scattered like an illusion.

The Dark Fragrance Drift of Huashan. It was the exact movement I had grown sick of watching during my duels with him in the past.

A year had passed, and his Dark Fragrance Drift had become even more secretive and faster.

Swish!

A faint violet aura gathered around the tip of the sword sweeping toward the crown of the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon’s head.

He avoided attacks as much as possible, and only used Sword Energy at the exact moment of striking.

It was proof that he was reducing unnecessary expenditure of internal energy while controlling his own power perfectly.

“Gah!”

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon, startled, hurriedly knocked his sword upward. But this time, things were different from before. The Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword slid along Cheongpung’s blade and changed direction.

Softness overcoming hardness.

That was the foundation of Wudang’s martial arts and the principle embodied by the Taiji Wisdom Sword.

But…

“Oh, I know how to do something similar too.”

Shhk.

Cheongpung’s wrist rotated fluidly as he spoke with childlike innocence.

The Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword had clung tenaciously to Cheongpung’s blade, pressing it down. But with that single motion, it was swept aside as if it had no strength at all.

The Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword wavered in midair, and Cheongpung’s blade immediately ensnared it.

“Got it. This is how you do it, right?”

“…!”

“Or not? Wait, I think it’ll work better like this. Ah, that’s it.”

Cheongpung abruptly withdrew his sword and sank into thought. Then he smiled brightly.

In contrast, the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon stared at him in utter shock.

So did every martial artist watching the duel.

“Gah!”

“T-The Taiji Wisdom Sword…!”

Strength was overcome by greater strength. Softness, by even greater softness.

Wudang had built its martial arts upon the principle of softness overcoming hardness, and the Taiji Wisdom Sword was its greatest supreme technique. Cheongpung had just defeated it through that very same principle.

The shock was immense.

Cheongpung is one move ahead of the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon. No, at least two moves ahead.

There was no way the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon, who was facing him directly, hadn’t realized it.

“H-How did you do that?”

“Hmm. You just have to think of embracing your opponent. Then your body reacts on its own and knows where and how to move. Easy, right?”

“…”

Easy, my ass. You crazy bastard.

More importantly, was that really something a person could do?

And this is the guy who supposedly spent a whole year eating nothing but dumplings.

As I stared at Cheongpung in disbelief, the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon’s eyelids trembled from the shock.

Then he suddenly charged.

Tzzzz!

Blue Sword Energy blazed more brightly than ever. He had clearly gathered every last bit of his internal energy into that one strike.

The blade approached as though it would split Cheongpung’s chest open at any moment. Just as the spectators began screaming at the sight of Cheongpung standing there blankly—

Swish-swish-swish-swish!

Brilliant violet light-flames filled the dueling arena. The sword in Cheongpung’s hand traced a beautiful path through the air.

That single movement told me exactly which martial art he was using.

The Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords.

It was supremely fast and smooth.

For a moment, it seemed as though the scent of plum blossoms brushed the tip of my nose. The violet Sword Energy of the Zaha Divine Technique burst like flower buds and bloomed into thirty-six plum blossoms.

The next instant, the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon's Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword stopped dead in front of Cheongpung's chest.

Crack.

The Sword Energy that had poured from it in torrents only moments ago had vanished. Hairline fractures spread like a spiderweb across the straight, snow-white blade.

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon stared at his cherished sword, and a weak voice slipped from his lips.

"Plum blossoms… I see. You are a disciple of Huashan."

Cheongpung jumped and stammered.

"Ah, I'm not."

"Well, I suppose it hardly matters."

Resignation—and understanding.

The Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon's arm slowly sank. His Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword shattered into hundreds of fragments that tumbled across the dueling platform.

"I concede."

Only then did the silence break.

The judge came to his senses and lowered the flag. The pent-up roar of the crowd burst free like a dam, sweeping through the arena from every direction.

"How was I? I did well, right?"

The innocent voice pulled me from my thoughts. Cheongpung's face was inches from mine, his eyes sparkling like a child's.

"Whoa, you scared me. Let's cut that out."

"Benefactor, I asked how I did."

Was the young man pestering me for an answer really the same person who had just fought?

The Invincible Divine Sword had utterly overwhelmed the Willow-Cloud Divine Dragon, one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes and the future of Wudang.

Watching the duel had reminded me once again that Cheongpung had long since surpassed the realm of young prodigies.

Was he always this strong?

The higher you climbed, the more of the landscape you could see. The same was true of the mountain called Cheongpung. A year ago, I hadn't been high enough to see this view.

He's incredible. It's almost impossible to believe that all of this comes from natural talent.

His martial prowess was astonishing, but his talent was even more so.

Watching him, even I could almost believe he was a System user.

“Benefactor. Why aren’t you answering?”

“Are you a child? Do I have to praise you for that too?”

Cheongpung muttered with a slightly downcast expression.

“Grandpa always told me I did well…”

“That’s your problem.”

Just as I answered him curtly on purpose—

“Wow, that was a great duel, friend!”

At the sudden voice that seemed to leap out of nowhere, Cheongpung turned around with a brightened expression.

“Jongni Chu!”

“Oh! You remember me, friend!”

“Of course I remember you. Of course I do—uh, yeah, of course!”

“…”

What a pair of fucking idiots.

I silently watched Jongni Chu and Cheongpung embrace and laugh together. Then a thought occurred to me.

“Wait. You two.”

“Hm? What is it?”

“Why?”

“Aren’t you each other’s next opponents?”

The two of them stared blankly at each other, then both gasped.

“T-That’s right!”

“I-I see. You’re my next opponent, Kang Pung.”

I could already hear their friendship cracking.

I clicked my tongue as they awkwardly pulled apart.

Well, the result is more or less obvious anyway.

As with everything else, luck played a part in the Star-Array Grand Banquet. In that respect, Jongni Chu had been blessed by the heavens.

For some reason, he had kept drawing middling opponents and made it all the way to the semifinals.

Of course, the opponents he had defeated only seemed middling to me. They had all been comparable to Jongni Chu or even stronger.

And apparently he even got a bye yesterday.

From what I’d heard, Jongni Chu’s quarterfinal opponent had suffered a severe injury and withdrawn.

Whatever else one might say about him, the bastard’s luck was phenomenal.

Still, making it to the semifinals is no small feat.

Cheongpung wasn't someone who could be defeated through luck. Perhaps they knew that too, because they exchanged a few words with regretful expressions.

"Sorry. I'll go easy on you. No, wait—sorry, pal. I'll go easy on you."

"If you would, I'd be grateful. Please do."

One openly promised to go easy on the other, while the other thanked him without a shred of pride. Neither of them was in his right mind.

I shook my head.

"You two childhood friends can settle that yourselves. I'm leaving. I have a prior engagement."

"A prior engagement? But Benefactor, you don't have any friends."

"What? Did you have any friends besides me?"

"…"

The saddest part was that I couldn't deny it.

Just as I found myself at a loss for words, the judge's shout, amplified by internal energy, rang through the arena.

"Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung! Come up to the dueling platform!"

"Yes, I'm coming."

Cheongpung and I each had one more step to climb before we could face each other in the finals.

I stepped lightly onto the dueling platform and looked at my opponent.

"You got lucky too. I never thought you'd make it this far."

My semifinal opponent muttered gloomily.

"Our sect's Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms is one of the five greatest palm techniques under heaven."

"But you've only mastered five tenths of it."

"That is correct."

"Then concede."

"If I did, my Master would beat me like a dog on Boknal.[1412]"

"Then?"

"There is only one path left."

Gung Gibang, the Successor Beggar of the Beggars' Sect, spat out a thick gob of phlegm. He pointed his well-worn bamboo staff at me and continued.

"Our sect's Dog-Beating Staff Technique is the greatest under heaven. I'll beat you senseless like a back-alley dog."

"Sure. Go ahead."

[1412] Boknal refers to the hottest days of the Korean summer, traditionally associated with eating dog meat.

Exactly fifteen minutes later, Gung Gibang clung to my calf, both eyes swollen, and shouted,

“I’ve only mastered five tenths of the Dog-Beating Staff Technique!”

“…”

Why was this bastard stuck at five-tenths mastery with everything?

As I tossed aside the bamboo staff, now split in two, the judge lowered the flag.

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung advances to the finals!”

Chapter 254

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung, wins!”

At the judge’s shout, tens of thousands of spectators rose to their feet as one.

As Jin Taekyung came down from the dueling platform beneath a storm of cheers and applause, the eyes of the man watching him were sunk deep in thought.

What a strange fellow.

The Dog-Beating Staff Technique was the Beggars’ Sect’s greatest secret art, one that could only be taught to someone who had become the Successor Beggar.

Despite its comical name, its power and the subtlety of its forms ranked among the top ten martial arts in the world.

And yet Jin Taekyung had countered it far too easily without using any particularly notable martial art.

He had shattered a bamboo staff infused with internal energy using his bare fist, and even after taking the Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms head-on, all he did was frown.

He had even seemed to deliberately take attacks he could have avoided. No, that had undoubtedly been his intention.

Why?

At first, Jongni Chu wondered if Taekyung was some kind of oddball who enjoyed pain, but judging by the agonized faces he made each time, apparently not.

Besides, what kind of lunatic would take the Dog-Beating Staff Technique head-on just to raise his Toughness?

Whatever the reason, he’s interesting.

Jongni Chu still could not forget the surprise he had felt when he first saw Jin Taekyung.

His Muscles and Bones seemed to have been bestowed by heaven itself. If there was such a thing as the Heavenly Martial Physique, surely this was it.

A Disciple of the Fire King… I’ll have to watch him closely.

With that final thought, Jongni Chu, the Always-Victorious Sword, turned away and blended into the cheering crowd.

Several pairs of eyes followed him.

A merchant with a generous belly, a hunched old man, a Third Rate martial artist and a wandering martial artist dressed in cheap martial-arts uniforms…

All of them had ordinary faces one might see anywhere.

Yet whenever their lips moved, Sound Transmission passed between them—a technique only Peak masters could use.

—Your orders, Pavilion Master.

—Two and Three will follow him. But stay at least a hundred zhang[1413] away.

—We may lose track of him.

—I know. But this is our best option.

—…Understood.

—Four and Five, keep an eye on Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung. If he approaches again, report it immediately.

—Yes, sir.

—Then I wish you all good martial fortune.

The brief conversation ended without another reply. The ordinary-looking figures continued walking as though nothing had happened and disappeared into the crowd.

Meanwhile, a middle-aged beggar sitting by the roadside continued bowing to the people who tossed him a few coins. Only after some time had passed did he rise to his feet.

The transformation began in a deserted alley.

Crack. Sssrk.

His hunched shoulders straightened, and his twisted spine grew perfectly erect. Then his facial muscles began to quiver as though invisible hands were kneading them.

Before he had taken ten steps, the middle-aged beggar had become a genial-looking old man.

Tap. Tap.

A wooden prosthetic leg made of ebony, hard as steel, struck the stone pavement.

Jongni Chu, the Always-Victorious Sword.

The old man, Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox, repeated the name in his mind.

Before he was the Pavilion Master of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, he was also an intelligence operative and a master of disguise.

He never forgot a face he had seen even once, and the smallest habit or the structure of a person’s bones was enough for him to recognize them. Even disguise techniques could not deceive his eyes.

But there was one exception.

Jongni Chu.

I’ve definitely crossed paths with that bastard before.

But when? And where?

Song Ho was deep in thought, recalling Jongni Chu’s face, when a stab of pain from his leg brought him to a halt.

It’s starting again. It’s been getting worse lately.

[1413] A zhang is ten cheok, a traditional length unit. Using 30.3 cm per cheok, a hundred zhang is about 303 m (994 ft).

It was a very old injury.

Decades ago, when he was still young, he had taken part in the final battle against the Demonic Cult and lost one of his legs.

After countless twists and turns, he had barely survived. But the memory of that day remained branded deep into his mind.

So did the voice of one man, deep and dark as a bottomless abyss.

Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho. You're quite large for a fox. Shall I start by tearing off a leg?

Song Ho shuddered all over, endured the pain, and started walking again.

That past was long gone. Not even its dregs remained. He had to focus instead on the far more tangible present.

Jongni Chu… who are you? And what are you plotting?

He had already finished making every possible preparation. Even so, the unease lingering in his chest kept shaking him.

Am I getting old? Or has the peace simply lasted too long?

A quiet sigh escaped the old man's lips.

I closed my eyes.

In the darkness, I pictured one person: a boyish face that always wore a bright smile and an unremarkable build.

But the moment he drew his sword, everything changed.

Whoosh!

I could see it without seeing. I could hear it without hearing.

Violet Sword Energy shot forth, leaving no opening in any of the thirty-six directions.

It was as swift as a ray of light and as gentle as drifting flower petals. As I watched that beautiful sight, I thought,

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, the Flame Divine Palm, or…

Several other martial arts flashed through my mind before disappearing again.

Cheongpung was an opponent I would have to face with everything I had. In the end, there was only one answer.

After a brief moment of thought, I reached for the cool shaft of my spear.

Creak.

"Captain. Captain."

The voice boring into my ear shattered my thoughts. Cheongpung and the illusory Sword Energy he had conjured vanished as if washed away.

When I lifted my eyelids, I saw Hyuk Mujin poking his head through the crack in the door.

“Hehe. I’m here.”

I stared at him for a moment before speaking.

“What are you doing here?”

“I came to keep you company in case you were lonely.”

“Keep me company?”

“Yes. Isn’t that thoughtful of me?”

“Thoughtful?”

I let out a deep sigh and pulled a leg off the chair.

“Get down on your stomach, you despicable bastard.”

“W-Why are you doing this?”

“Did Cheongpung send you to interrupt my training?”

“Gasp! You were training?”

“Then do you see people sitting cross-legged and falling asleep?”

Mujin glanced around nervously before speaking hesitantly.

“I heard that when you were young, you tried to practice Horse Stance while sitting in a chair.”

“That wasn’t me… Wait. Did you just talk back to me?”

“What? Am I not even allowed to talk back?”

What the hell? Had this guy gone crazy?

I stared at Hyuk Mujin in disbelief. In the past, he would have thrown his hands over his head at once. Now he merely flinched before puffing out his chest.

“What are you doing?”

“Now that the subject has come up, I believe I’ve made no small contribution while serving you, Captain.”

“So?”

“Treat me accordingly.”

“What kind of treatment? The four mandatory insurances? Workers’ comp if you get hurt from now on?”[1414]

“I don’t know what the four mandatory insurances or workers’ comp are, but if you keep treating me like this, I’ll quit and take over the textile shop.”

I thought it over, then nodded.

“Go ahead.”

“Pardon?”

[1414] Korea’s four mandatory social-insurance programs cover national health insurance, national pension, employment insurance, and industrial accident compensation insurance.

“Good work. No—thank you for your hard work, Mr. Mujin. May your textile shop prosper from here on out.”

“Wait. Wait a moment.”

“Oh, right. I don’t know about the other locations, but prepare to close the main branch in Shanxi Province.”

Grab!

Hyuk Mujin wrapped his arms around my calf and spoke with an imploring look in his eyes.

“I misspoke.”

“Did you?”

“Yes. Please hit me once on the back of the head.”

“Didn’t you ask me to treat you accordingly?”

“No. I’ve become a man who can’t live even a day without your blows.”

“…”

Had he gone insane?

I shook my head and lightly tapped him on the forehead.

“Enough nonsense. Get to the point. Why are you here?”

“The thing is, I really did come to keep you company.”

“What?”

When I glared at him, Mujin’s voice grew even smaller.

“I thought you might be feeling pressured since the final is tomorrow…”

“My opponent hasn’t even been decided yet. Don’t you know today is the last day of the semifinals?”

The sun was beginning to set, so Jongni Chu and Cheongpung’s duel would start soon.

The winner would face me in the final, and barring some enormous upset, Cheongpung was certain to win.

Mujin shrugged at my words.

“I know. I stopped by anyway.”

“What a silly guy. Use this time to train, you idiot.”

That was what I said, but something stirred warmly in a corner of my heart. Come to think of it, Mujin had been through a lot while following me around.

Maybe his occasional deranged behavior was because I had destroyed too many of his brain cells by smacking him in the back of the head.

Now that I think about it, I feel bad.

I was resolving to treat him better from now on when Mujin asked,

“Cheongpung will win, right?”

“Of course he will… Wait. How do you know that?”

“Even if no one else does, I need to know. With that ridiculous epithet, Invincible Divine Sword, his name being Kang Pung, and the fact that he used the Zaha Divine Technique in his last duel, how could I not?”

“You’re smarter than I thought.”

“Rumors have been spreading too. Cheongpung isn’t particularly famous, so most people have only figured out that he’s a disciple of Huashan.”

He had a point. The Zaha Divine Technique was distinctive enough for people to deduce that much.

“So Cheongpung is definitely going to win, right?”

“Isn’t it obvious?”

“It has to be certain. Absolutely!”

What was with that greedy look in his eyes?

The moment I nodded uneasily—

“Waaaaah!”

A roar echoed from not far away.

I picked up White Flame, the spear resting beside me, and rose to my feet.

Cheongpung will advance anyway. That won’t change.

This was clearly a fight between an egg and a rock.

But watching how the egg collided with the rock, and how the rock shattered the egg, would be a great help in the final duel.

“What are you doing? Aren’t you getting up?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Life-Sustaining Sword!”

“I bet one silver nyang[1415] on you! Pull off the upset!”

“Hahaha! You bet on the Life-Sustaining Sword instead of the Invincible Divine Sword? There’s no bigger sucker!”

Jongni Chu was climbing onto the dueling platform amid blazing torches and peals of boisterous laughter when he suddenly stopped.

It was because of the gazes looking down at him from the seats of honor.

No fewer than three of the Supreme Peak masters known as the Ten Kings were present. He could also see the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, as well as Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox, watching quietly from the very back with gleaming eyes.

“Jongni Chu, the Always-Victorious Sword. Take your designated position.”

[1415] A silver nyang is a historical denomination of silver currency; its value varied by time and place.

His pause lasted only an instant. At the judge’s words, Jongni Chu trudged onto the dueling platform and drew his sword without hesitation.

Ssshing!

The sudden action made the surrounding crowd fall silent for an instant, but quiet snickers soon broke out.

The hilt was so caked with dirt that its pattern could not be made out, while the blade was covered in reddish rust.

Martial artists ordinarily cherished their weapons as they did their own lives, but Jongni Chu’s sword looked as though it had never been cleaned once since the day it was forged.

“What the hell is that?”

“I thought something serious was happening. Gave me quite a start.”

“That’s why they call him the Life-Sustaining Sword. What did you expect?”

Ignoring the laughter behind him, Jongni Chu scrutinized the rusty blade and clicked his tongue.

“I can’t use this for now.”

Just then, Cheongpung, who had been enthusiastically waving to the crowd, held out his own sword.

“Want to borrow mine? Ah, would you care to use mine?”

“No. You should use that.”

“I’m fine, though…”

“You’re fine? Then what will you use?”

“It doesn’t matter. We’re friends.”

Cheongpung nodded vigorously, and Jongni Chu let out a genial laugh.

“I appreciate the thought. Mine will be enough.”

“But we’re friends…”

“Listen.”

Sssrk.

The rust-red blade pointed at Cheongpung.

The playfulness in Jongni Chu’s eyes had vanished. Now only torchlight flickered within them.

“I’ve never had a friend like you.”

Chapter 255

Crash!

Jeok Cheongang shot to his feet, not even noticing the chair toppling behind him.

Every one of his senses was focused on a single person: Jongni Chu.

“This is…”

The moment had been so brief it could scarcely be called an instant, but he had definitely felt it.

The wave of qi emanating from Jongni Chu had been powerful enough to make his eyes fly open.

“Returning to Simplicity… He was hiding his strength.”

Dharma King Hong Dao groaned the words, his voice filled with sheer astonishment.

Returning to Simplicity. It was a realm that allowed a martial artist to appear no different from an ordinary person. Their bulging temples flattened, and they could control their aura at will.

To reach such a realm, one had to set foot beyond Peak—

into the realm of supreme mastery permitted only to the greatest martial artists.

“That young punk is a Supreme Peak master? Have you all gone mad? How could that possibly make sense?”

At the Thunderbolt Saber King’s barrage of questions, Hong Dao and Jeok Cheongang shook their heads.

“Amitabha.[1416] Then how would you explain this, Benefactor Peng?”

“He has reached the realm of Returning to Simplicity. Enough to deceive even our eyes completely.”

The people in the seats of honor, who had been listening closely to the three men’s conversation, gaped in shock.

Jongni Chu had scraped through every round from the preliminaries onward, always advancing by the narrowest of margins. Why else would people have given him the mocking nickname Life-Sustaining Sword?

But no longer.

The qi they had sensed from that supposedly lucky young martial artist, brief though it had been, was powerful enough to send chills down the spines of even the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Family Heads of the Five Great Families.

“What in the world…”

The Thunderbolt Saber King fell silent.

[1416] *Amitabha* is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

He, too, was a Supreme Peak master and one of the Ten Kings. Deep down, he agreed with Jeok Cheongang and Hong Dao, but he could not bring himself to accept it so easily.

"How could someone who isn't even thirty be a Supreme Peak master?"

As the Thunderbolt Saber King muttered in dismay, someone who had been silently observing the situation spoke up.

"It's possible."

"What?"

Every head turned in the same direction.

Their gazes demanded an explanation, and Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho gave them one.

"If he has Returned to Youth."

"…!"

Leaving the shock spreading through the gathering behind him, Song Ho leaned back in his chair and stared at Jongni Chu with brooding eyes.

Who are you?

The more the question swelled within him, the worse the pain grew at the stump where his leg had been severed decades ago.

Song Ho knew now.

This was no mere coincidence.

Jongni Chu was closely connected to the day he had lost his leg.

Show me your true face.

At that moment, the judge's flag shot into the air.

Whoosh!

A red arc swept through the air without hesitation. Cheongpung had stood there blinking, and by the time he twisted aside, it was already too late.

Jongni Chu's strike was faster than he had expected.

Slice!

A searing pain spread across his chest. The long slash through the front of his robe welled with beads of crimson.

The sharp scent of blood stung his nose.

"…Ah."

Cheongpung stumbled backward and stared blankly at Jongni Chu.

His friend—or rather, the man he had thought was his friend—gazed back with disconcerting calm.

"Too bad. It was too shallow."

Just as Jongni Chu had said, the wound was shallow. The blade had only grazed the skin, leaving no deeper injury.

But Cheongpung's wound was not merely one of flesh.

"J-Jongni Chu."

He was the first friend Cheongpung had ever made in the Murim—no, in all his twenty-two years of life.

The man who had first held out a hand and asked to be friends was now pointing a sword at him. Without the slightest hesitation, he had swung it and cut Cheongpung across the chest.

"Why…?"

"I don't understand what you mean."

Jongni Chu casually flicked the blood from his sword.

"This is the Murim, isn't it? Don't tell me you completely trusted someone you'd only just met after exchanging a few words."

"…!"

"Judging by your expression, you did. How have you survived this long with so little sense? I heard you were a Disciple of Huashan."

He glanced at the Heavenly Sword True Person, the Huashan Sect Leader seated among the honored guests, and clicked his tongue.

"The Sect Leader did a terrible job teaching his Disciple. Pathetic."

At those words, Cheongpung's tightly pressed lips parted. Unlike before, his voice was low and formal.

"The person who taught me martial arts was my grandfather. Not that man."

"Really? Whoever he is, he must be a senile old fool. What's the old man's epithet?"

"The Sword Saint."

"The Sword Saint Mae Jonghak?"

Cheongpung nodded, and astonished cries burst from the silent stands.

Not a single person present was unfamiliar with the illustrious name of Sword Saint Mae Jonghak. He had long since become a living legend.

And now the Disciple of the Sword Saint, who had vanished for decades, had appeared.

Right here!

Countless eyes widened in shock. Only one man remained unmoved.

"The Sword Saint's Disciple…"

Jongni Chu stroked his smooth chin out of habit, then gave a quiet laugh.

"Then the Sword Saint is nothing special either."

"…!"

"A child is still a child, no matter how strong he is. You shouldn't carelessly leave one by a river. Look away for a moment, and the current will sweep him off."

Cheongpung suddenly remembered something his grandfather had always told him.

Always remember this. The world is vast, and there are many strong people. Your martial arts are not yet complete, so you must always beware those who harbor malicious intent.

At the time, those words had meant little to him. Huashan had been peaceful, and his days with Mae Jonghak had been happy.

But his curiosity about the outside world had grown with each passing day, until he finally left without his grandfather's knowledge.

And then…

Ah. So this was what he meant.

Only now did he understand.

It merely hurt that he had needed to bleed by the sword of his first-ever friend before realizing it.

Grandpa.

Cheongpung tightened his grip on his sword hilt. The scent of blood lingering beneath his nose faded, and his mind cleared.

Ssshing.

With a sound that set his hair on end, a pure white blade slid from its sheath.

At the same time, the internal energy coiled in his dantian rose like a cloud, covering his acupoints and spreading in billowing waves.

Tzzzzzz!

The distinctive purple qi of the Zaha Divine Technique blossomed across Cheongpung's entire body. His eyes, filled with the colors of sunset, fixed on Jongni Chu.

"You'll regret this."

"Then…"

Jongni Chu rested his lowered sword against his shoulder.

"Let's see what you can do."

Whoosh!

Cheongpung jerked his head back. Jongni Chu's sword passed within a paper's width of the bridge of his nose. Instead of Sword Energy, the blade was thickly coated in reddish rust.

Fast!

Cheongpung had mastered a supreme eye technique under his grandfather's guidance, but Jongni Chu's movements surpassed even that.

A warning bell rang in his head as a wave of sword strikes followed.

Whoosh! Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

The blade slashing toward his chest changed course in midair.

A thrust became a slash, then the slash gave way to an unexpected palm hurtling toward his shoulder.

Boom!

“Urgh!”

The palm struck Cheongpung’s shoulder and sent him flying more than ten zhang.[1417]

He spun through the air like a top. The instant his feet touched the ground—

Boom!

The bluestone paving the dueling platform exploded into powder.

Cheongpung surged toward Jongni Chu even faster than he had been thrown back.

His sword streamed purple Sword Energy as it danced with effortless grace, flowers blooming in its wake.

Ssshhh!

The Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords, executed with eight-tenths mastery, scattered around Jongni Chu from every direction.

Surrounded by purple Sword Energy, Jongni Chu suddenly curled his lips into a smile. It was wholly out of place amid such mortal peril.

“This is more than I expected.”

Before he had even finished speaking, the sword in his hand moved.

A blinding flash and deafening roar erupted, so intense that the spectators could not keep their eyes open.

Boom! Krrrraaaash!

Sword Energy exploded, spraying shattered fragments through the air.

The thick cloud of dust billowed upward, then split apart to reveal a lone figure.

Cheongpung’s eyes widened as he watched Jongni Chu cover his mouth and cough softly.

This man…

This time, he had seen it clearly.

He had seen Jongni Chu deflect every last strand of Sword Energy.

The dozens of Sword Energy attacks capable of piercing steel had been countered by none other than his rusted sword.

Not a trace of Sword Energy coated the blade, yet it had swept every attack aside, redirecting them as naturally and effortlessly as flowing water.

How is that possible?

Along with his astonishment, Cheongpung was seized by a strange emotion he had never felt before.

[1417] A *zhang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten zhang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft); five zhang is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

His heartbeat thundered in his ears, and the hand gripping his sword hilt would not strike.

A bead of sweat gathered on his forehead, rolled down the bridge of his nose, and fell.

“Are you afraid?”

Jongni Chu strolled toward him at a leisurely pace. His deep, cold gaze made Cheongpung’s heart sink.

Then Cheongpung realized that the word Jongni Chu had just spoken was the name of this strange emotion.

“…Afraid?”

It was an emotion he had never experienced before.

Fear was a foreign feeling he had only ever heard of from his grandfather. Now it constricted both his body and mind.

Pung. Do you know fear?

Fear? What’s that?

Something that hides deep in everyone’s heart. Not knowing fear is your greatest weakness.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had deeply loved the grandson who shared none of his blood. His gaze had always been warm, and he had cared for Cheongpung day and night.

Just as beautiful flowers bloomed from good soil, Cheongpung had grown into a lovable child.

This old man is at fault. I shouldn’t have done that…

Having grown up surrounded by boundless love, he had learned only how to love.

On the mountain peak where grandfather and grandson lived happily together, there was none of the arrogance, greed, jealousy, or anger that overflowed in the outside world. The child had grown without ever learning how terrifying human malice could be—or what it meant to feel fear.

If that day ever comes, do not let fear devour you. That is all I can tell you.

His grandfather had said those words the day before Cheongpung secretly left Lotus Peak.

Perhaps he had known this would happen.

But faced with a master unlike any he had ever encountered, Cheongpung found himself backing away without even realizing it.

Grandpa, what do I do?

Step.

Whenever Jongni Chu advanced a step, Cheongpung retreated.

Another step.

Then another.

The distance between them remained fixed at five zhang[1418] as Jongni Chu raised his sword.

“This could go on forever. I expected more from the Sword Saint’s Disciple. Is this all you amount to?”

“I-I…”

“You do know what it means to lose in the Murim, don’t you?”

Ssshhh.

A ghostlike movement.

Paralyzed by fear, Cheongpung could not react. In a world slowed to a crawl, Jongni Chu alone seemed to move unhindered.

One step erased the distance between them, and his sword glided forward.

Just as the rusted blade was about to pierce Cheongpung’s throat—

Swoooosh! Boom!

A terrifying sound split the air, followed by a boom loud enough to leave his ears ringing.

Jongni Chu twisted his sword at the last instant and blocked the attack. At the sight of the translucent spearhead, he grinned.

“As expected, you’ve got a good friend.”

“He’s not a friend. He’s my Benefactor. But…”

Jin Taekyung spat out a wad of phlegm and continued,

“What the fuck are you?”

[1418] A *zhang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten zhang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft); five zhang is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

Chapter 256

“What the fuck are you?”

Jongni Chu’s eyes curved like half-moons at the loaded question.

“Do I need to tell you again?”

“Jongni Chu from Yunnan. Yeah, I know. So…”

My next words came out calm enough to surprise even me.

“Who are you? You.”

“Shouldn’t you catch that friend behind you first?”

Jongni Chu was right. I caught Cheongpung by the arm as he crumpled.

There was a little bleeding from the shallow cut across his chest, but it was nowhere near enough to bring down a master of Cheongpung’s caliber.

“What did you do to him?”

“Nothing. His mental strength merely took a blow.”

“If anything happens to Cheongpung…”

“You worry too much. It was only a feint, so nothing like what you’re imagining will happen.”

“A feint? That strike just now?”

“If you don’t believe me, I can’t help that. Friendship is a wonderful thing.”

As I watched Jongni Chu smile gently, my stomach burned as though I had swallowed a ball of fire.

He fooled me completely.

I remembered when we had first met.

He had been a cheerful loudmouth who asked to become friends, saying even brushing sleeves was enough to forge a connection. Annoying, yes, but I hadn’t disliked him.

Now, though, I didn’t know what to think. Everything about him was shrouded in mystery.

My hand tightened around White Flame of its own accord.

“W-Wait!”

The urgent voice belonged to the judge. He was visibly flustered by the unexpected turn of events.

“Both of you, step back. And Young Hero Jin, barging into a duel violates the rules of the Star-Array Grand Banquet.”

Without taking my eyes off Jongni Chu, I answered.

“So I’m supposed to stand there and watch while someone nearly gets killed?”

“B-But he said it was only a feint!”

“That’s what he says.”

The judge bit his lip at my firm reply.

“If you don’t withdraw now, you may be disqualified under the rules.”

“Disqualified?”

“Of course. You don’t want to be disqualified with the final still ahead of you, do you?”

I laughed under my breath.

Winning the Star-Array Grand Banquet would certainly earn me a huge amount of EXP and Fame, or perhaps an even greater Reward.

Jin Wikyung would hug me for raising the family’s reputation, and Jeok Cheongang would be pleased as well.

But that’s all it would be.

The year I had spent in Fire Gate Cavern had not been for the sake of winning the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

And the same was surely true of the sinister bastard standing before me.

“Let’s fight.”

Jongni Chu deliberately widened his eyes.

“Now?”

“Yeah.”

“Good grief. If you don’t withdraw immediately, you’ll be disqualified.”

“I don’t give a damn about that.”

“Thank you. Thanks to you, I’ll be able to win easily and make my name known throughout the world.”

“Cut the crap. Drop the lousy acting and tell me what you really think.”

Jongni Chu paused, then grinned.

“I was right about you. You really are an interesting friend.”

“Friend? That’s not the word you use in a situation like this. Especially not between you and me.”

“That stings a little, but… well, it can’t be helped.”

“So what’s your answer?”

“I did want to fight you at least once.”

The judge, who had been listening to us, cut in with a grim expression.

“Did you not hear what I said? Under the rules, the Star-Array Grand Banquet final must take place tomorrow.”

At that moment, a low voice pierced everyone’s ears.

“Then change the rules as of today.”

“Who dares!”

The judge spun around with a roar, only to freeze at the sight of the tiny old man who had approached like a ghost.

“G-Great Hero Jeok?”

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. His eyes glowed faintly red as they passed over me and Jongni Chu before settling on the judge.

“That’s right. It’s me.”

“I-I apologize. I misspoke.”

“Forget it. Get the next duel underway immediately.”

“B-But…”

“But?”

The judge swallowed hard.

“To change the schedule, we must hold a meeting and receive the presiding chair’s approval.”

“The Martial God presided over the first Star-Array Grand Banquet. After he disappeared, the position passed to the Abbot of Shaolin, who could be considered the organizer. Is that correct?”

“Y-Yes, that’s correct.”

“Then it’s settled.”

“Pardon?”

“Hong Dao had to step away on urgent business. Considering seniority and standing in the Murim, I am the presiding chair now.”

Everyone’s eyes turned toward the seats of honor a hundred zhang[1419] away. Just as Jeok Cheongang had said, the seat where Dharma King Hong Dao should have been sitting was empty.

No. There was one more person missing.

Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox.

Two important people had left at the same time. What was going on?

The question flashed through my mind, then vanished. That wasn’t what mattered right now.

“Now we can forget about those damn rules or whatever they are. Am I wrong?”

The judge hesitated, then nodded.

“No. We’ll proceed.”

“Good. And you.”

Jongni Chu, who had been watching the scene with great interest, pointed at his own chest.

“Me?”

“Yes, you, the bastard with half a tongue.”

“My tongue hasn’t been cut in half, but I understand.”

[1419] A zhang (丈) is a traditional length unit of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred zhang is about 303 m (994 ft); eighty zhang is about 242 m (795 ft).

Even though he clearly knew who he was dealing with, he remained completely unruffled.

Jeok Cheongang fixed Jongni Chu with a grave, steady glare.

“I’ll ask you directly. Did you come from Tianshan?”

The Tianshan Mountains. The headquarters of the Demonic Cult.

The judge flinched as though he had touched a flame, while Jongni Chu wore a faint smile, as if enjoying the situation.

“I think I’ll save that answer for later.”

“If you don’t want to die young, you’d better think carefully before answering.”

Jongni Chu rubbed his smooth chin.

“What will you do if some unfortunate accident occurs before you hear my answer?”

“An accident?”

“You never know what might happen in the Murim. For example, a certain master might lose his only Disciple.”

At that moment, a deathly silence pressed down on the surroundings.

Jeok Cheongang stared at Jongni Chu with emotionless eyes before speaking.

“If such a regrettable thing were to happen… the master who lost his Disciple would become very angry.”

“Would you kill the culprit even if you had to spread a net over heaven and earth?”

“Of course not. I’d burn him alive. You have my word.”

“Aren’t you making quite a promise? You don’t even know who we’re talking about.”

“Coincidentally, it’s someone I know very well.”

“Oh, dear.”

Jongni Chu burst into cheerful laughter.

“Then I suppose I’ll have to go easy on him.”

“Are you underestimating my Disciple?”

“I’m looking forward to it, but he probably won’t be a match for me.”

“That’s what he says. What do you think?”

At Jeok Cheongang’s question, I tightened my grip on the spear shaft.

“That bastard’s thinking is pretty screwed up.”

Jongni Chu looked at me with amusement.

“I can’t tell whether that’s confidence or arrogance.”

“Neither. I want to live a long, full life. But there’s one thing I do know.”

I enunciated each word clearly.

“You don’t know anything until you try.”

“Good thinking. But will that still hold true this time?”

“I hope so.”

“You could die.”

“That’s why I have to give it everything I’ve got. If I die after that… well, I’ll feel like shit, but someone will avenge me. Won’t they?”

Jeok Cheongang nodded.

“Go in peace. I’ll avenge you, so don’t worry about what comes after.”

“Seriously? You call that comforting?”

“Then stop talking nonsense and remember one thing. If that bastard kills you, I’ll kill you myself.”

“If I don’t want to die twice, I’d better work hard.”

Jongni Chu burst into loud laughter as he listened to us.

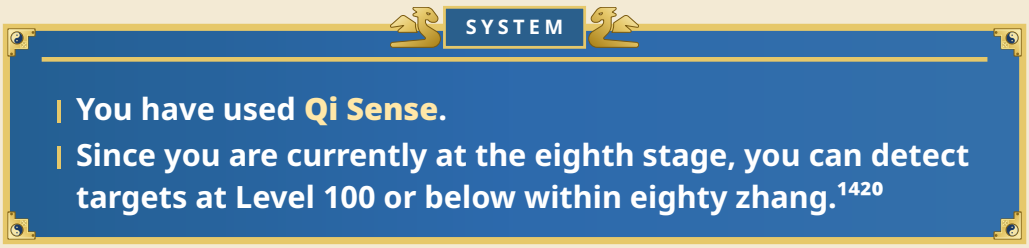
“Ha-ha-ha! What an interesting Master and Disciple pair.”

I stared at him and muttered inwardly.

Before we fought, I needed to peel back even a little of the veil surrounding him.

Skill, Qi Sense.

A chime rang.



I possessed two kinds of Qi Sense: the Qi Sense that existed as a Skill, and the Qi Sense I had developed as a martial artist.

When I first came to the Murim, I had relied entirely on the former. But as time passed, I realized that Level and strength were not directly proportional, so I gradually used it less and less.

The Murim had too many variables to judge anyone by Level alone.

Show me something. Even a little. Show me what you really are.

Swoooosh!

Once Qi Sense reached the eighth stage, I could focus it entirely on a single person.

A blue line visible only to me shot forward without hesitation and reached Jongni Chu.

No—just as I thought it had reached him—

Beep!

[1420] A zhang (丈) is a traditional length unit of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred zhang is about 303 m (994 ft); eighty zhang is about 242 m (795 ft).

SYSTEM

Qi Sense has failed!
Unable to identify the target!
An unknown force is rejecting the Skill!

"...!"

What?

My eyes flew open at the unbelievable System notification. I stared at Jongni Chu in confusion.

The blue line of Qi Sense had seemed to strike something, circled around him, then disappeared.

"What the hell did you do?"

"That's what I'd like to ask you."

Jongni Chu had stopped laughing. His interested gaze settled on me.

"You have quite an interesting trick."

His words suddenly brought back a memory from a year ago—the first person who had ever detected my Qi Sense.

Well, aren't you an interesting fellow?

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

As befitted a Supreme Peak master, he had been able to control his qi freely. Through that encounter, I had first realized that the System was not omnipotent.

But even Jeok Cheongang couldn't repel the Skill.

And now an unknown force had rejected the Skill. I had never heard of anything like it.

The more I saw Jongni Chu violate common sense, the more one word floated through my mind.

Demonic martial arts.

Martial arts that defied reason.

My suspicion hardened into certainty. At last, I understood the meaning behind the question Jeok Cheongang had asked him earlier.

"You really are from the Demonic Cult, aren't you?"

"Beat me and I'll tell you. What kind of trick did you use?"

"Even if you beat me, I won't tell you."

"That puts me at quite a disadvantage. It can't be helped."

Sssrk.

The rusted sword slowly rose and pointed between my eyebrows.

A humming voice followed, utterly at odds with the suffocating edge of his sword.

"Come. Let's have some fun."

I raised White Flame and answered.

“Yeah. Let’s have a brutal good time.”

Fwoosh!

The fire dragon curled within my dantian awoke from its slumber and stretched.

Give it everything you’ve got.

Jeok Cheongang used Seizing an Object Through Empty Space to pull Cheongpung toward him, then stepped through the air as he retreated. At the same time, the judge’s frantic voice rang out.

“Under the revised schedule, the Star-Array Grand Banquet final will begin immediately! The Life-Sustaining Sword—no, the Always-Victorious Sword, Jongni Chu, and the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung…!”

The judge’s announcement was already meaningless.

We were already charging toward each other.

Swoooosh!

One step. The distance vanished.

Krrrraaaash!

Two steps. Two streaks of light bursting from our hands collided in midair.

Chapter 257

Rrrrrumble.

The ground trembled faintly as a distant roar rolled in.

The commoners who knew nothing of martial arts merely tilted their heads and continued on their way.

But the Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho, was different.

This is…

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion agents secretly following him sent messages through Sound Transmission.

—About seven hundred zhang[1421] north.

—Something appears to have happened at the dueling platform.

—Pavilion Master, your orders.

Song Ho hesitated. His wealth of experience told him that the roar had been caused by the aftereffects of martial arts.

And not just any martial arts…

A Supreme Peak master?

Even if one turned the entire world upside down and scraped it bare, there might not be more than thirty Supreme Peak masters in existence.

The aftermath he had sensed clearly indicated a clash between Supreme Peak masters.

This was no ordinary matter. Had the Always-Victorious Sword, Jongni Chu, finally made his move?

But adequate precautions should already be in place.

They had already searched every inch around the Murim Alliance. They had thoroughly inspected everyone and everything in preparation for any possible situation, even taking into account the possibility that explosives might have been brought in and planted.

A tiger was still a tiger even after losing its teeth. The Hidden Shadow Pavilion might not have been what it once was, but its intelligence network was still capable of controlling Henan Province.

And three of the Ten Kings are there.

Then there were the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang, the Family Heads of the Five Great Families, and the elites of the sects and families they had brought with them.

It would be no exaggeration to call that place the Murim world in miniature.

I must be getting old. Perhaps I've worried too much.

[1421] A zhang is a Chinese unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Seven hundred zhang is about 2.1 km (1.3 mi).

It was all because of those unknown beings who had yet to reveal their true identities.

Song Ho clearly remembered the conversation he had shared with the Dharma King, Hong Dao, when the man had come to find him a year ago.

Dark clouds are covering the sky.

Could they be clouds from Tianshan?

I don't even know where they're coming from or when they'll arrive. All I have are two words: Dark Heaven.

Dark Heaven…

Help me. I need your strength.

Half a century had passed since the Great Faction War.

The fox who had left the secular world and buried himself in the countryside had returned to the realm of martial artists, only to be reminded of just how much time had passed.

The Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho, let out a shallow sigh and moved his lips.

—Tell the Abbot I'll leave once I finish my business.

A Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent who had joined them seven and a half minutes later replied.

—Dharma King Hong Dao left after you did, Pavilion Master.

—The Abbot left?

—Yes.

Song Ho hesitated briefly, then shook his head. He did not know what had happened, but he trusted Hong Dao's judgment.

Hong Dao would trust his in turn.

—One of you, go to the dueling platform. Two will remain here. Report immediately if anything happens.

—Understood.

—The rest of you, follow me. As soon as we arrive, seal off the entire area. Let nothing slip through.

—Yes, sir.

Whoosh!

Black figures scattered through the alleyways.

As Song Ho raced across the endless rows of rooftops, his thoughts remained fixed on the report he had received fifteen minutes earlier.

We found Shadow Killer.

Tap!

He drove his wooden crutch down harder, accelerating with qinggong.[1422]

[1422] Qinggong is a Chinese martial-arts skill associated with swift, light-footed movement and extraordinary leaps.

The pain intensified in equal measure.

Bang!

White Flame's transparent spearhead collided with the rusted blade.

A single exchange.

A roar that seemed to split the heavens rang out, and a violent blast of wind engulfed my entire body.

Kraaaaoom!

A whirlwind rose around us, blocking everyone else's view.

Amid the dust clouds raging in every direction, I saw Jongni Chu staring wide-eyed at me over our locked weapons.

"Impressive. I didn't expect to be pushed back."

Sssrk.

Just as he said, he had been forced several steps backward. Clearly, he could not withstand my strength, which had long since surpassed the limits of the human body.

But…

What the hell is this bastard?

If Jongni Chu was surprised, I was stunned.

I had spent an entire year training with an iron ball weighing more than a thousand catties[1423] attached to me. Both my martial arts and my stats were worlds apart from what they had once been.

And he withstood that?

That exchange should not merely have given me the upper hand. I should have overwhelmed him completely.

Yet all Jongni Chu had done was retreat a few steps.

Even that rust-covered sword had not broken.

Who the hell is this guy?

A bead of cold sweat slid down the back of my neck.

A playful smile tugged at Jongni Chu's lips.

"Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties. Rather than trying to overpower your opponent, you must read the flow."

"…"

Kaaaang!

His blade coiled around my spearhead and wrenched it aside.

[1423] In this Chinese setting, a catty (jin) is about 500 g (1.10 lb). A thousand catties is about 500 kg (1,100 lb).

I tightened my grip on the shaft, but the more force I used, the more it felt as though I were sinking into a swamp.

Jongni Chu's sword was the horse, and my spear was the cart. The cart had no choice but to follow wherever the horse led.

The instant White Flame's transparent Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron spearhead plunged into the ground, Jongni Chu thrust out his palm.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded in front of my chest, and my vision swam.

I barely kept myself from being hurled backward. Clinging to the spear shaft buried deep in the ground, I spun around it and closed in on Jongni Chu.

Blue flames gathered around my right foot, which carried one jiazi[1424] of internal energy.

Flame Wheel Kick.

The blazing flames slammed into the back of Jongni Chu's neck.

Bang!

He slid backward and lowered his elbow.

His blackened sleeve crumbled into ash and scattered through the air.

"Too bad. I liked this outfit."

Crack. Crack.

He rolled his neck from side to side like some Third Rate street thug, then grinned.

"But truly, you're impressive. I'm liking you more and more. Now…"

Whoosh!

His figure vanished with a sharp rush of wind.

A quiet voice pierced my ear from right beside me.

"Let's get started for real."

Hummm.

The wind stopped.

This time, my senses were one step ahead of my body. At the last instant, I crossed my arms, and Jongni Chu's fist slammed into them.

It was a strike carrying an enormous amount of internal energy, unlike anything he had used before.

Kra-boom!

Its power surpassed all ordinary limits. Though it was only flesh colliding with flesh, the resulting roar sounded like a bomb exploding.

Even after anchoring myself with the Thousand-Catty Drop at the last instant, I bent backward until my waist nearly touched the ground.

Crack.

[1424] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; here it describes sixty years' worth of internal energy.

Even my extraordinary Muscles and Bones, fine enough to be called the Heavenly Martial Physique, were useless this time.

I clenched my teeth and endured the sharp pain running along my spine.

How dare this bastard.

Boom!

I slammed my free left hand into the ground.

I shot upward two or three times faster than I had fallen. Jongni Chu's brightly smiling face appeared before me.

I roared.

"I haven't even gotten to use this back yet!"

The fire dragon stretching through my four limbs and hundred bones surged toward my open palm.

A scorching gale erupted with lava-like heat.

The martial art that had once driven me to the brink of death—the Flame Divine Palm—collided with Jongni Chu's punch.

Bang!

My ears rang, and the ground shook.

Still gripping White Flame, I was hurled backward.

I sprang to my feet and saw Jongni Chu standing perfectly still beyond the hazy cloud of dust, the entire dueling platform charred black around him.

"That was a poor choice. As you can see, internal energy happens to be one of my strengths."

I glared at his serene smile, then coughed up a surge of blood.

The blood was black.

Proof that I had suffered an Internal Injury.

Damn it.

My opponent was a Supreme Peak master who had reached the realm of Returning to Simplicity.

I had expected him to be strong, but he was far stronger than I had imagined.

Even allowing for the fact that he had learned demonic martial arts, it was difficult to understand how someone that young could possess such martial power.

"What the hell are you, really?"

I wiped the blood from my mouth with my sleeve.

Jongni Chu let out a hollow laugh.

"That's what I'd like to ask you. I never thought I would encounter a monster like you in my lifetime."

"Now you're fucking with me, too?"

"I'm sincere."

“Sincere, my ass. If I’m a monster, what does that make you?”

“I’m… a little special. Let’s leave it at that.”

I studied Jongni Chu’s enigmatic smile, then spat out a mouthful of bloody phlegm.

My insides burned from the Internal Injury.

“Is this another one of those legendary demonic martial arts?”

“Whenever people encounter something beyond the bounds of common reason, their thoughts turn to the word ‘demonic.‘ It is difficult to accept things for what they are.”

“Yeah, it really isn’t easy. So what kind of demonic martial art did you learn?”

“Any further exchange of questions would be a waste of time.”

Jongni Chu raised his sword and pointed it at me.

Streams of qi as clear as mountain water flowed from the blade and took shape.

Sword Force.

The concentrated manifestation of energy permitted only to those who had set foot in the exalted realm of the Supreme Peak.

Tzzzzzzzz!

The mere sight of it chilled me to the bone.

The aura pouring from Jongni Chu left my palms damp and my lips parched.

This is… dangerous.

I drew a deep breath.

I had lost count of how many brushes with death I had survived.

What mattered was that I had survived every one of them.

And it would be the same from now on.

Wasn’t that why I had followed the Fire King and endured training that had seemed utterly impossible?

One shichen of sleep a day. Every moment left over goes into training!

That damn old man.

The words Jeok Cheongang had spoken before my training began in earnest suddenly came to mind, drawing a short laugh from me.

One shichen, my ass.

I had been allowed only half a shichen.

Without the System’s power to rapidly restore my body, I could never have endured those days.

My sleeping time had dwindled while the iron ball grew heavier and heavier. Even under those brutal conditions, I had punched, kicked, and swung my spear.

“That really was the perfect move.”

“Hmm?”

“My Master was right. Sleep is a luxury for a martial artist. And…”

Status Window, open.

As soon as I muttered the words inwardly, a holographic window filled my vision.

A great deal had changed over the past year—the Level displayed in my Status Window, the numbers, and even the number of Titles.

But only one thing mattered right now.

“Repeat Quests are fucking awesome.”

Endlessly repeating the same training meant one thing: Repeat Quests.

Then there were the points I had gained from leveling up.

The points I had diligently deposited over the past year had become a hefty lump sum. Just looking at them filled me with satisfaction.

“This is why people need to save.”

“What does that mean?”

Jongni Chu tilted his head, unable to understand my words.

I grinned at him and raised White Flame.

“It means things are about to get a little harder for you.”

At the same time, countless System commands echoed through my mind.

Strength. Agility. Stamina.

Muscles and Bones. Sinews and Meridians.

Everything advanced another step. New power gathered, connected, and seeped into me.

In a world slowed almost to a standstill, I took a step.

Swish.

There was no sound.

One step carried me directly in front of Jongni Chu.

The Fire Dragon Divine Spear, now at the seventh stage, danced along the spearhead, burning through air and sound alike.

Papapapapat!

The spearhead became streaks of light that poured toward every part of Jongni Chu’s body.

At the same time, his sword, wrapped in transparent Sword Force, moved.

Kwaaang!

Within a moment split and split again, we exchanged dozens of blows.

I saw Jongni Chu’s eyes widen in astonishment.

The roars erupted without end, overlapping one another.

Perhaps this was what it would sound like if the heavens collapsed.

Screeech! Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Whenever spear and sword parted, fist met palm.

Each time I narrowly evaded an attack and retreated, another was already waiting where I landed.

Krrrzzzt!

A single punch and a single kick created massive craters, laying waste to everything around us.

The impossibly solid dueling platform became riddled with pits and cracks spreading like a spiderweb.

But more astonishing than anything else was Jongni Chu.

“Incredible! Truly incredible!”

He laughed as he unleashed one form after another, his eyes shining with joy.

Even though I was fighting with all my strength, his movements kept growing faster.

Stronger.

What the hell is this bastard…?

My mind wavered, and my hands and feet fell out of rhythm.

That shattered composure immediately led to a mistake.

Pow-pow-pow!

“Gah!”

My vision flashed white as excruciating pain surged through me.

I staggered backward.

Jongni Chu watched me with open admiration.

“Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. I’ll remember you well. You truly are…”

At that moment, Jongni Chu’s expression hardened.

As if drawn by something, he stared fixedly into the distance.

Then he abruptly kicked off the ground and shot upward.

Bang!

It all happened in an instant.

I stared blankly at his back as he stepped on empty air and vanished.

Then I snapped out of it and screamed after him.

“Where are you going, you son of a bitch!”

Chapter 258

I saw red.

“Where the hell are you going, you son of a bitch!”

If this had happened before, my first thought would have been, *Why is he suddenly leaving?* Maybe I would even have breathed an inward sigh of relief at escaping the crisis.

But not now.

This bastard beats the hell out of me and then runs?

Unlike me, who was still at the Peak realm, Jongni Chu was unquestionably a Supreme Peak master. I could admit that he was several levels above me.

But to leave before the duel had even been decided?

I gritted my teeth. Ignoring the Internal Injury needling my insides, I focused all my internal energy into my lower body.

“Stop right there.”

Crack! Boom!

I launched myself into the air with a thunderous blast. Cold wind slapped my face, and Jongni Chu’s foot appeared right in front of me.

He was close enough to touch if I simply reached out. One certainty flashed through my mind.

Got you.

Whoosh!

But the spearhead I thrust out with a triumphant smile sliced uselessly through empty air.

I blinked, unable to understand what had happened.

How?

Even with my seventh-tier grades[1425], I knew the law of universal gravitation. Jongni Chu’s body had already reached its highest point and was falling, while I was still rising with the momentum of my leap.

He had definitely been close enough for me to grab his ankle with my bare hand.

But in my certainty, I had overlooked one crucial fact.

Martial artists—Supreme Peak masters in particular—were beings who shattered common sense.

“What the hell…”

The curse slipped through my parted lips. The sight unfolding before me was that shocking.

[1425] South Korean school-record grades run from 1, the highest, to 9, the lowest. Seventh-tier grades are low marks.

Papapapat!

He was stepping on the air.

There were no walls. No branches. Nothing at all.

As though invisible stairs had appeared beneath his feet, Jongni Chu climbed through empty air, soaring higher and higher.

Stepping on Empty Air…

What kind of bullshit was this? How was I supposed to catch him?

Cursing inwardly as I fell, I saw the confused crowd below.

Among them stood a tiny old man, his eyes gleaming coldly.

“You bastard! How dare you run!”

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

His roar shook the heavens as a streak of red light shot from his wrinkled hand. A sword imbued with Extreme Yang internal energy crossed dozens of zhang[1426] in an instant and struck its target.

Rumble-rumble-boom!

The air trembled, and a flash of light burst in midair, stabbing at my retinas. When I opened my eyes again, I saw Jongni Chu plummeting.

No. I had to correct myself.

That isn’t a fall.

Unfortunately, unlike my previous prediction, I was right this time.

Jeok Cheongang’s low groan was the proof, and Jongni Chu’s body shooting away like an arrow was the result.

He blocked it.

Jongni Chu had not only blocked Jeok Cheongang’s sword. He had used the tremendous internal energy behind it as propulsion, accelerating in the direction he wanted.

It was an astonishingly clever and efficient choice—one that was difficult to believe he had made in that split second.

Screeeeeech!

Now there was no one who could stop Jongni Chu as he shot through the sky like a meteor from that dizzying height.

Tap.

The instant I landed on the devastated dueling platform after experiencing the law of gravity firsthand, Jeok Cheongang’s furious voice rang out.

“What are you doing? Chase that bastard immediately!”

Everything had happened without warning. Only Jeok Cheongang’s shout jolted the leaders in the seats of honor into action.

[1426] A zhang is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“Capture Jongni Chu, the Always-Victorious Sword!”

“Seize the Demonic Cult spy plotting some vile scheme! Whoever captures him, dead or alive, will receive a great reward!”

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families. Even influential sects that wielded considerable power in their respective provinces.

Everyone gathered here was a key figure who moved the Murim.

Naturally, their attendants were renowned Peak masters in their own right.

“Yes, sir!”

Hundreds of martial artists scattered in every direction. At their head were Jeok Cheongang, the Thunderbolt Saber King, several other leaders, and me.

Screeeeeech!

We raced ahead of everyone else. I could not keep pace with Jeok Cheongang, who had mastered the Fire Gate Clan’s signature movement technique, Flamefire Path, to the ninth stage, but I was fast enough to keep his back in sight.

When you don’t have teeth, you make do with your gums.

My movement technique was still at a low stage, and my martial arts had yet to break past the uppermost reaches of the Peak realm. But my physical abilities had already surpassed their limits, making such speed possible.

“How’s your Internal Injury?”

“I can manage.”

I nodded in response to Jeok Cheongang’s voice through the fierce wind.

At that moment—

Ding.

SYSTEM

Under the rules, ???, who left the dueling platform first, has been declared the loser by ring-out!
Quest, Star-Array Grand Banquet, completed successfully!
Great Achievement, Star-Array Grand Banquet Victory, achieved!
Rewards will be distributed according to the participants' caliber and the difficulty of the competition!
You have obtained a vast amount of EXP and Fame, as well as additional Points!
Level up!
Level up!
Level up!

.
.
.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

As System notifications relentlessly rang in my ears, the changes began.

Vitality flooded my exhausted body, and the Internal Injury that had been stabbing at my insides vanished without a trace. The fire dragon in my dantian, drained by our all-out exchange, stirred and surged through my limbs and every corner of my body.

I never expected to win the Star-Array Grand Banquet like this.

But I had no time to check the System messages.

Finding Jongni Chu, who had vanished ahead of us, came first.

"Damn it. Whoever that bastard is, he's fast as hell."

Just as Myriad-Mile Pursuit—the Beggars' Sect Leader and a master of qinggong[1427]—had said, Jongni Chu was unimaginably fast.

He had long since disappeared from everyone's sight. Jeok Cheongang quickly issued orders.

"We'll lose him at this rate. The Beggars' Sect will take the west. The Kunlun Sect and the rest of you cover the gaps."

"Yes, Great Hero Jeok."

"Understood."

Papapat!

[1427] Qinggong is a martial-arts movement skill associated with exceptional speed and lightness.

The Sect Leaders of the Beggars' Sect and Kunlun Sect—two sects renowned for their movement techniques—vanished with their disciples in tow. Jeok Cheongang turned to the Thunderbolt Saber King.

"You take the east."

"Then what about this direction?"

"I'll handle it."

The Thunderbolt Saber King's expression was grim.

"Be careful. That bastard calling himself the Always-Victorious Sword… He'll be difficult to handle alone."

Difficult to handle?

Those words had come from the Thunderbolt Saber King, a man whose pride was second to none.

In other words, Jongni Chu was comparable to the Ten Kings—or perhaps even stronger.

Jongni Chu was that powerful?

How had someone so young reached such a realm?

He was a monster among monsters. As I swallowed my surprise, Jeok Cheongang snorted.

"That only applies to weaklings like you. Don't lump this old man in with the rest of you."

He said it like a joke, but it was obvious he had not dismissed the Thunderbolt Saber King's warning.

The corners of Jeok Cheongang's mouth were raised, but his eyes had gone cold and still.

"That's enough grumbling. Get going."

"Damn it. Even the heavens are heartless. Why did Hong Dao, that damn monk, have to disappear at a time like this?"

After leaving behind a single lament, the Thunderbolt Saber King turned away and vanished from sight.

Now only Jeok Cheongang and I remained.

We continued at high speed, leaping over rooftops and racing past the hundreds of buildings stretching endlessly before us as we exchanged words.

"If you find him, do not act rashly. Understood?"

"I can't promise that. I have a score to settle."

"Jongni Chu is beyond your ability to handle. Do not engage him until I give the order."

"Just how strong is he?"

After a brief silence, Jeok Cheongang's lips parted.

"I don't know."

“What do you mean by that…?”

“Even I could not determine what martial arts he had learned or what realm he had reached.”

“…!”

First the famously proud Thunderbolt Saber King, and now Jeok Cheongang—who ranked among the strongest of the Ten Kings in terms of sheer martial power—had given such an answer.

I was licking my parched lips when—

Kwoooong!

Far in the distance, a cloud of dust rose with a thunderous roar. Screams and shrill whistles rang out from every direction, announcing the enemy’s appearance.

I opened my senses wide and gathered the information.

West. About five hundred zhang[1428] away.

That was the direction of the Beggars’ Sect.

If I pushed my movement technique to its limit, I could reach it in moments.

“Old Master!”

“I know.”

Boom!

Jeok Cheongang and I shot forward like cannonballs.

The scenery whipping past us began to change. The endless rows of pavilions dwindled one by one, and tall city walls came into view.

The harder we ran against the fierce pressure of the wind, the heavier my chest felt.

What is this feeling?

Could it be the pressure of facing Jongni Chu again?

I glanced sideways. Jeok Cheongang’s expression had hardened. The emotion etched across his face was unmistakable foreboding.

A moment later, we discovered the source of that inexplicable feeling.

“Chase that bastard!”

“Master! Please come to your senses, Master!”

A massive pit about thirty zhang[1429] wide.

Through the gathered Beggars’ Sect disciples, I caught sight of a blood-soaked monk’s robe.

A wrinkled hand trembled at irregular intervals. Below where both legs had been severed, a pool of blood had formed, and prayer beads stained crimson with their owner’s blood bobbed on its surface.

“…Damn monk?”

[1428] A zhang is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1429] A zhang is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Jeok Cheongang's steps stopped dead when he saw his friend.

Jeok Cheongang's vision went hazy.

Their last conversation echoed endlessly in his ears.

"Something came up. I need to step away for a while."

"Now?"

"I'll take care of it and be right back."

"Is it something small or something serious?"

"Amitabha.[1430] As Shakyamuni[1431] said, if you resolve the greater matter first, the smaller matter will resolve itself."

"That damn Amitabha. This is why people call you a damn monk."

"What does it matter whether I'm a Buddha or a damn monk? Ha-ha-ha."

He remembered clearly how Hong Dao had left with a laugh half a shichen[1432] ago.

But why…

Why are you lying here like this?

Splash.

Mud and bloody water splattered. The Beggars' Sect disciples surrounding the fallen old monk hurriedly stepped aside and bowed their heads.

"G-Great Hero Jeok!"

"Our Sect Leader is pursuing Jongni Chu. B-but by the time we arrived, it was already too late…"

"Move."

The voice that slipped from Jeok Cheongang's lips was as dry as spent ash.

Every sound stopped. It was as though the world itself had frozen.

His senses were already focused on one person alone.

"I'm here."

It was the same greeting as always. But instead of Hong Dao's sly voice, a labored cough answered him.

Cough.

The Dharma King Hong Dao's chest heaved, and black blood spilled from the corner of his mouth.

A grave Internal Injury. Fragments of his organs were mixed into the blood. There was no need to examine him to know what had happened inside his body.

[1430] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

[1431] Shakyamuni is a name for the historical Buddha.

[1432] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“Well, now. Your friend is here, and you couldn’t even wait for me before lying down again?”

Jeok Cheongang spoke calmly as he dropped down beside Hong Dao.

He grasped the blood-soaked old monk’s wrist and sent internal energy into him. What he had suspected became reality.

Beyond saving.

The painful, crushing verdict filled Jeok Cheongang’s mind.

“Do you remember when we first met? Back when we fought those Demonic Cult bastards in Gansu almost every day?”

Was Hong Dao listening? Could he even hear him?

Everyone shared the same question, but Jeok Cheongang paid it no mind and continued speaking.

“At first, I wondered what kind of damn monk you were. But they say even dislike can become affection, and when the time came to part with you, I found myself reluctant.”

Although he had never once said it aloud, Hong Dao was the only friend Jeok Cheongang had ever opened his heart to.

To his Master, he had needed to be a reliable Disciple. To the first Disciple he later accepted, he had needed to be a dependable Master.

But with Hong Dao, it was different.

When he was with Hong Dao, he did not have to be anyone’s anything. He could simply be Jeok Cheongang, an ordinary human being.

“Did you know?”

Jeok Cheongang sent internal energy into Hong Dao’s Mingmen acupoint and spoke in a low voice.

“You’re my best friend.”

The breath that had been so weak it seemed ready to stop at any moment eased. The eyelids that looked as though they would remain closed forever finally opened a sliver.

A final rally.

Jeok Cheongang gazed into Hong Dao’s gray eyes as the final flame of life flickered within them.

“Speak. Anything at all.”

Hong Dao’s blood-soaked lips moved faintly. Jeok Cheongang put his ear to Hong Dao’s mouth and listened to his final words, his expression changing by the moment.

Anger. Shock. The realization of something.

And the final emotion to appear was sorrow.

Slowly. Then with a soft thud.

The coughing voice fell silent. The heaving chest and trembling eyelids settled peacefully.

Hong Dao closed his eyes as though he had fallen asleep, a satisfied smile still resting at the corners of his mouth.

Jeok Cheongang stared at him before opening his mouth.

“We’re going to Shaolin.”

His voice boiled like molten lava.

Chapter 259

Dharma King Hong Dao.

He was the Abbot of Shaolin, known as the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim[1433], and one of the Ten Kings. He had breathed his last.

Here in Henan, of all places—at Shaolin's doorstep, where the Star-Array Grand Banquet was being held.

"H-How could this happen?"

"Master Hong Dao!"

Sorrow and shock weighed upon everyone gathered there, but my gaze remained fixed on one person.

I spoke toward his back, which had gone rigid as a plaster statue.

"Old Master—no, Master."

Jeok Cheongang, who had been looking down at Hong Dao's corpse, turned his head.

"I'm going to Shaolin."

His voice boiled like molten lava.

The blade-sharp aura pouring from the entire body of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, made it difficult to breathe and prickled my skin.

Only his eyes were cold and still.

He was clinging to the last thread of his reason, suppressing the urge to hunt Jongni Chu down and tear him apart this instant.

What could possibly take precedence over avenging his dearest friend?

"Was that Master Hong Dao's final wish?"

"Later. Every moment counts right now."

Just as Jeok Cheongang finished speaking, dozens of presences rapidly approached from the distance. At the head of the group, the Thunderbolt Saber King stared wide-eyed at the scene before him.

"H-Hong Dao!"

"There's no time to be shocked. Listen carefully."

Jeok Cheongang continued without pause.

"I'm heading straight to Shaolin. Inform everyone and gather them together. Not a single moment can be wasted."

"Do you intend to cast a net over heaven and earth to capture Jongni Chu?"

"The opposite."

"What?"

[1433] "Mount Tai and Northern Dipper" is an expression for a figure or institution held in the highest esteem.

"The Myriad-Mile Pursuit[1434] is tracking him, but he is certain to fail. Once everyone is assembled, bring them straight to Shaolin."

"Did you say Shaolin?"

"Yes."

Jeok Cheongang nodded gravely.

"If Hong Dao's final words are true… a storm of blood will soon descend upon Shaolin. It may have already begun."

"…!"

The shocking declaration plunged everyone into silence. Even the Thunderbolt Saber King stood there gaping, and I was no different.

Shaolin Temple?

What kind of place was Shaolin Temple?

It was a temple and martial sect of such stature that it was only natural to call it the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim. Shaolin had stood for a thousand years.

Some even claimed that the Murim itself had begun with the arrival of Bodhidharma.[1435]

It was the holy ground of Buddhism and the central seat of martial arts. Even if Shaolin's power waned, its deep-rooted history and the respect of the people remained unshaken.

And now a storm of blood was going to descend upon Shaolin Temple.

"W-What do you mean? Hong Dao's final words? And who would dare to—"

"Hah!"

Kwoooong!

Jeok Cheongang's roar jolted everyone back to their senses. The Thunderbolt Saber King stopped rambling and clamped his mouth shut.

"Dark Heaven. They've begun to move. If this old man's guess is correct, we'll eventually see Jongni Chu—that bastard who deserves to be torn apart—in Shaolin as well."

"Dark Heaven…!"

Several leaders, including the Thunderbolt Saber King, opened their eyes wide. Judging by their reactions, they had clearly received at least some warning already.

"Do you understand now why every moment counts?"

Jeok Cheongang turned away from the Thunderbolt Saber King and swept his deeply sunken gaze across the gathering.

[1434] Myriad-Mile Pursuit is the epithet of the Beggars' Sect Leader, renowned for his movement techniques.

[1435] Bodhidharma was a Buddhist monk traditionally associated with the origins of Chan Buddhism and with Shaolin.

"Do exactly as I have said. That is Hong Dao's final will."

There was no time left to waste. Jeok Cheongang and I exchanged a glance, unleashed our movement techniques, and left the area simultaneously.

Whoooosh!

As I raced through the fierce wind, something cold touched my cheek.

The sky was clear and cloudless. There was no sign of rain.

But the eyes of someone running after losing a friend and postponing his revenge must have been brimming with tears.

No. It's rainwater.

I'll call it rainwater.

Damn it.

I clenched my teeth as I thought of Jongni Chu.

I have a feeling today is going to be a long day.

Shrill whistles pierced the air.

"Find the culprit!"

"He may still be hiding nearby!"

"Everyone, remain calm! Nothing is going to happen!"

The Murim Alliance buzzed like a kicked hornet's nest.

The countless martial artists attending the Star-Array Grand Banquet were scouring the surrounding area for Jongni Chu with fire in their eyes, while anxious commoners followed the orders of those directing them.

They're wasting their time.

They still did not know that Jongni Chu had already fled far away—or that Dharma King Hong Dao was dead.

For a moment, I considered telling them, but quickly dismissed the thought.

It would only add to the confusion.

Besides, I had no time to seek out every leader and explain what had happened. It was only a matter of time before they found out for themselves.

Right now, keeping pace with Jeok Cheongang took everything I had.

Fortunately, Shaolin Temple isn't far.

That was our one piece of good fortune. After I passed the preliminary competition, the carriage ride from Mount Song to the Murim Alliance had taken roughly three shichen.[1436] At the speed we were traveling with our movement techniques, we could shorten the journey dramatically.

Whoooosh!

[1436] A *shichen* is a traditional period of about two hours; three shichen are about six hours.

After racing like the wind for some time, the bustling crowds and tightly packed buildings fell away, giving way to fields and rice paddies.

As we crossed the broad plain, Jeok Cheongang, who had led the way in silence the entire time, suddenly spoke.

“Jongni Chu. Dark Heaven. Unnamed. Buddhist Staff.”

Four words uttered in a hoarse voice.

To anyone unaware of the circumstances, they would have sounded like a random list. I understood immediately.

They were the answer I had been waiting for.

“Were those Master Hong Dao’s final words?”

“Yes. Even that took every last bit of strength he had.”

“…”

“It would not have been strange if his breath had already stopped. He held on only to deliver those words to me.”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice trembled faintly, then settled again.

“What do you think?”

“It’s as you suspected, Old Master.”

“It is only a suspicion, not a certainty. Tell me everything. Leave nothing out.”

“The first two words seem to mean that Jongni Chu belongs to Dark Heaven. That hardly needs explaining.”

“And?”

“Unnamed and the Buddhist Staff… I’m not sure. Honestly, I don’t know.”

“Do you remember Hong Dao’s Disciple?”

“Oh, of course.”

The memory of our meeting a year ago remained vivid.

The young warrior monk I had met at an inn in Henan had been Dharma King Hong Dao’s Disciple. He had introduced himself as Unnamed.

So that was the Unnamed Hong Dao meant.

Had Hong Dao used his final moments to ask Jeok Cheongang to look after his Disciple?

“But what’s this Buddhist Staff? Do you mean the kind of staff monks carry around?”

Jeok Cheongang nodded.

“Yes. But the Buddhist Staff Hong Dao meant was the Green Jade Buddha Staff, Shaolin’s sacred treasure.”

“The Green Jade Buddha Staff?”

A scene suddenly came to mind from the day Jeok Cheongang and Hong Dao had reunited after a long time and chatted with laughter.

What choice did they have? They were the ones who forced the Abbot's seat on someone who said he didn't want it.

The Green Jade Buddha Staff. To entrust a sacred treasure of thousand-year-old Shaolin—one with such immense authority—to a damn monk like this… They must all have been completely blind.

The staff Hong Dao had taken from his robes that day had been absurdly short, its smooth surface gleaming with a faint green light.

I had wondered what it was, and the revelation that it was Shaolin's sacred treasure had surprised me.

"But why would the Green Jade Buddha Staff be part of his final words?"

"Not long before his death, Hong Dao told me he had entrusted the Green Jade Buddha Staff to his Disciple."

I frowned slightly, and Jeok Cheongang continued.

"The Green Jade Buddha Staff is not only Shaolin's sacred treasure. It is also the symbol of office that the Abbot always carries."

"Ah!"

The exclamation escaped me before I could stop it. A realization flashed through my mind.

Hong Dao's final words, wrung from him with the last of his strength.

The reason Jeok Cheongang had turned toward Shaolin, postponing even the revenge for his dearest friend.

"The Green Jade Buddha Staff!"

"Exactly."

Jeok Cheongang's low voice continued.

"Dark Heaven's true objective is not Hong Dao's death. It is the seizure of the Green Jade Buddha Staff."

Now everything was clear.

Jongni Chu—or rather, Dark Heaven—clearly wanted Shaolin's sacred treasure.

Hong Dao had squeezed out the last of his strength to leave those final words and reveal that fact.

Now that Dark Heaven knew the Green Jade Buddha Staff was not in Hong Dao's possession, even a three-year-old could tell where they would go next.

A storm of blood will descend upon Shaolin.

As I recalled Jeok Cheongang's warning to the Thunderbolt Saber King, my thoughts went cold.

"Huff, hoo…"

Tap-tap-tap-tap!

Ragged breaths. Feet pounding without pause.

An aged voice brought the middle-aged man racing along the mountain path to a halt.

“You seem to have urgent business, young friend.”

The speaker was an old man with a beard that hung to his chest.

Tall, with his hair neatly arranged, he looked at first glance like a retired scholar.

“The weather is lovely. Why not slow down and enjoy the scenery?”

The middle-aged man’s throat bobbed heavily.

His voice emerged taut with tension.

“Who are you?”

“Just an old man out for a stroll. I heard the scenery on Mount Song was splendid, so I came to pass the time.”

“Pass the time?”

The middle-aged man shouted through clenched teeth.

“Enough bullshit! You must be another vile fiend!”

“Hm?”

The old man’s eyes widened before he let out a quiet laugh.

“You have quite a fiery temper, young friend. Still, you’re much better than the people I met earlier. They were far too busy lying.”

“You met people earlier… Don’t tell me?”

“A woodcutter, an herb gatherer. Why are there so many kinds of gatherers around here? Ah, the pair who disguised themselves as husband and wife to pray for a child were at least convincing. I almost fell for them myself.”

“…!”

“So I killed every last one of them, martial artists and commoners alike. It seemed much easier that way.”

The middle-aged man trembled as if struck by lightning.

There could be no doubt. His companions, who had scattered in every direction to deliver the urgent report, were already dead.

He would probably suffer the same fate soon.

At least I should be grateful that my death will not be meaningless.

Those on the ground had been caught in the net.

The sky was another matter.

He found a sliver of comfort in the sight of a messenger eagle flying powerfully across the distant plain.

Screeeeech!

A strange, piercing cry rang out as something black swooped down upon the messenger eagle.

It was three or four times larger at a glance. The battle between the two birds that collided in midair ended far too quickly to leave any hope.

Kreeee!

The messenger eagle plummeted with a final shriek. Blood seeped between the middle-aged man's tightly clenched teeth.

"Dark Heaven…"

"Oh? You know us?"

"How could I not? You old bastard who has outraged heaven and man!"

"Most of the Beggars' Sect beggars knew nothing about us. Your martial arts are too respectable for you to be Lower District Sect riffraff… Ah, that's it. You're from the Hidden Shadow Pavilion."

The old man stroked his beard and raised the corners of his mouth.

"But I find that 'outraged heaven and man' remark rather unpleasant. What do you think?"

"You dare do something like this and still—"

The middle-aged man opened his bloodshot eyes wide and was about to shout when the old man shook his head.

"No, not you."

He raised one withered finger and pointed over the middle-aged man's shoulder.

"I was asking that fellow."

"…!"

Crack!

The middle-aged man could not turn his head.

Heaven and earth flipped, and his vision shook.

Only one sensation remained at the end.

Hot.

Fwoosh. Thud.

His charred corpse crumpled.

A foot came down upon the middle-aged man's head, crushing the lump of charcoal beneath it.

"Han Su, you bastard. What kind of bullshit are you pulling? Wasting your time playing with trash like this."

The rough voice belonged to a thickset old man. His beard had grown wild and, strangely enough, was red.

At the appearance of an old friend who had been with him for decades, the old man who looked like a scholar smiled faintly.

"I was just about to wrap things up and leave. How are things up the mountain?"

"They're busy having their fun. Oh, apparently that Disciple of his has the Green Jade Buddha Staff."

“Is that so? Then let’s go together, Flame Tiger.”
The two exchanged faint smiles and began walking at a leisurely pace.
With each step, the screams coming from Shaolin Temple drew closer.

Chapter 260

“Young Hero Cheong. Young Hero Cheong, wake up.”

Smack! Smack!

“Mmm…”

Cheongpung opened his eyes with a groan.

Someone was slapping him hard across the face. It was his first time being slapped, so the experience was fascinating in a way, but for some strange reason, it also felt rather unpleasant.

Ah. So this is why people don’t like being slapped.

With that small insight, Cheongpung opened his mouth.

“Excuse me.”

Smack! Smack!

“I’m aw—”

Smack! Smack!

“I’m awake…”

Smack!

Only after landing one last slap did the hand finally stop.

A familiar-looking young man spoke with a stiff expression.

“You’re awake. Do you remember who I am?”

“It’s been a while, Warrior Hyuk Mujin.”

Hyuk Mujin sighed.

“So you do remember me.”

“Of course. I just never expected we’d meet like this.”

Cheongpung remembered Hyuk Mujin as a good person.

But when a good person he had not seen in a year was slapping him across the face, even Cheongpung could not help but feel hurt.

“I apologize if I offended you. I suddenly remembered the money I lost.”

“What?”

“No, the situation was so urgent that I forgot my manners.”

“Oh…”

If that was the reason, Cheongpung could understand.

He nodded and looked around. Shouts rang out from every direction, and people were running everywhere.

“Is this a festival?”

“…Does this look like a festival?”

“It isn’t?”

“No.”

Hyuk Mujin answered firmly, then gave him a brief account of the situation.

Dharma King Hong Dao had been found dead, and the culprit was none other than…

“Jongni Chu?”

“Yes. The Always-Victorious Sword, Jongni Chu. That bastard. His exact identity remains unknown, but most believe he was an assassin sent by the Demonic Cult.”

“The Demonic Cult…”

It was a name Cheongpung had heard countless times from his grandfather, the Sword Saint. A place where fiends and vicious killers who had once stained the entire world with blood had gathered.

And Jongni Chu was an assassin from that very Demonic Cult.

Cheongpung shook his head without realizing it.

“No.”

“What do you mean…?”

Hyuk Mujin continued with an incredulous expression.

“You suffered at his hands yourself, and you still don’t understand? The shock must have been so great that you can’t remember, but you nearly died at his hands.”

No. Cheongpung remembered everything clearly.

The helplessness and fear he had felt before a master against whom nothing worked. Even that final moment, when he had contemplated death for the first time in his life.

I was scared. Truly scared.

The mere thought made the fine hairs on his body stand on end and his palms turn clammy.

But why?

Why did Jongni Chu’s face keep appearing before his eyes—that bright smile he had worn when asking Cheongpung to be his friend?

Cheongpung’s lips remained pressed tightly together for a moment before finally parting.

“He’s my friend.”

“…What?”

“That man is my friend. He couldn’t have done it.”

“Young Hero Cheong!”

Startled, Hyuk Mujin hurriedly glanced around.

Only after confirming that no one was paying attention to them did he lower his voice.

“Are you insane? Jongni Chu is already as good as an enemy of the entire Murim. How can you call someone like that your friend…?”

He was an assassin who had murdered the Abbot of Shaolin Temple and fled. Simply being acquainted with Jongni Chu could be enough to earn Cheongpung a brutal beating.

Even if he was the disciple the Sword Saint had raised like his own flesh and blood, people would still glare at him.

“Never mention him out loud again. Do you understand?”

“But…”

Cheongpung was about to say something, but he closed his mouth at the look in Hyuk Mujin’s eyes.

“He’s a demonic fiend. I don’t know what kind of underhanded trick he used to win your favor, but it was all a disguise meant to help him assassinate Master Hong Dao.”

“Are you certain? Did anyone see him kill him?”

“All the circumstances point to it. The pursuit party formed to capture him and the thousands of heroes who gathered to save Shaolin have finished preparing to depart.”

“Shaolin…”

“The Demonic Cult’s vile scheme has placed Shaolin in danger. Great Hero Jeok and the Captain have already gone on ahead.”

Cheongpung slowly closed his eyes.

In the pitch-black darkness, the faces of Jin Taekyung and Jongni Chu flashed before him in turn.

He did not deliberate for long.

“I’ll go ahead.”

“What?”

By the time Hyuk Mujin asked back with a dazed expression, Cheongpung had already shot far into the distance.

His feet carried him toward Mount Song.

Mount Song was beautiful and peaceful enough to be counted among the Five Sacred Mountains.

But the place that should have been green and lovely was stained with blood and filled with screams.

“Aaaaaagh!”

“Kill every last one of them.”

Slash! Shhhhhhk!

Blood spurted from every direction whenever a flash of sword light gleamed.

In broad daylight on the peaceful day of Baekjung,[1437] hundreds of masked men had appeared without warning and begun slaughtering people with emotionless eyes.

“Protect the pilgrims! Do not retreat!”

Shaolin martial monks with Buddhist precept seals carved into their foreheads stood against them, but the situation showed no sign of improving.

The masked men were all exceptional masters and difficult enough to fight on their own. On top of that, the martial monks had to protect the scholarly monks who had never learned martial arts, the young novices, and the countless pilgrims.

“Wh-what is this?”

“Kraaagh!”

No one had expected anything like this to happen today.

Who would dare invade the grounds of Shaolin Temple, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim, in the very heart of the Central Plains?

The monks were being swept aside by the cruel, treacherous masked men when—

“You bastards! Do you even know where you are?”

A short old monk barely five feet tall[1438] appeared with a thunderous shout.

He glared at the masked men staining Shaolin Temple’s grounds with blood, cold blue sparks blazing in his eyes.

“Demonic martial arts! So you’re the demonic fiends of Tianshan!”

Palm force erupted from the old monk’s hands and swept across the grounds.

Kwoooong!

The masked men rushed him after noticing his presence too late, only to be swallowed by the palm force and killed.

It was an overwhelming sight. More than ten masters were crushed by a single attack.

However…

“The Lord of Heaven has commanded us. Kill the enemy.”

“Follow Heaven’s command. Kill them all.”

The hundreds of masked men did not stop.

They possessed neither agitation nor hesitation. They merely muttered as though possessed by ghosts and swung their swords.

Slash. Slash. Slash.

The old monk’s expression hardened at the sight.

How ruthless…

[1437] Baekjung is a traditional Korean Buddhist observance held on the fifteenth day of the seventh lunar month.

[1438] The source gives his height as five *cheok*. One *cheok* is 30.3 cm (11.9 in), making five *cheok* about 1.52 m (5 ft).

Even when their limbs were severed and their intestines spilled out, they did not so much as twitch an eyebrow.

They slaughtered without feeling pain or fear, then dropped like puppets with their strings cut. The sight sent a chill through him.

These things aren't human. They're Fiends incarnate.

If even an old monk who had fought his way through the Great Faction War felt that way, how much worse must it have been for everyone else?

The more experienced middle-aged martial monks were struggling valiantly, but the young monks witnessing such carnage for the first time trembled with fear.

Yet they did not retreat.

Perhaps it was the sense of duty that came with being disciples of Buddhism standing face-to-face with Fiends.

I never thought this day would come.

The old monk lamented inwardly.

During the last Great Faction War, Shaolin had been at the forefront more than anyone and shed more blood than anyone.

It had been a noble sacrifice that saved the Murim, but Shaolin had lost many elders and much martial knowledge. And the sacrifices of that era had returned today as tragedy.

Of all times, this had to happen while my Senior Brother, the Abbot, was away!

There was no helping it. He was the only one who could defend Shaolin now.

The old monk, Hongcheon, gritted his teeth and unleashed a lion's roar.

"This is Shaolin!"

His name might have been overshadowed by that of his Senior Brother, Hong Dao, but he too was a master who had reached the Supreme Peak realm.

Though the outside world knew nothing of his abilities, his ceaseless devotion to martial arts had already carried him beyond Hong Dao.

"Come at me, all of you!"

Kwoooong!

Palm force imbued with mighty Buddhist internal energy swept out in every direction.

At that moment—

"Oh-ho. The Hundred-Step Divine Fist?"

"We get to see that damned martial art again."

Two voices pierced Hongcheon's ears.

Two men slowly entered the temple grounds. As soon as they appeared, the masked men lowered their swords and withdrew in perfect unison.

"Was it you bastards?"

At Hongcheon's snarled question, the red-bearded old man picked his nose and answered.

"That's right. This old man right here."

"You're the vile demonic fiends of Tianshan."

"The demonic fiends of Tianshan? Well, that's half right and half wrong. But I'll let it pass."

Hongcheon paused.

"You're not from the Demonic Cult?"

"What does that matter? All you need to know is that I'm the one who'll grab your shiny pate and rip it off."

The old man with the air of a great scholar answered with a quiet smile.

"Flame Tiger, are you going to handle him?"

"Naturally. Now that I've seen the Hundred-Step Divine Fist, I can't just let it go."

"I keep telling you to rein in that temper of yours."

"I'll think about it later. Right now, I want to kill that bald monk more than I care about my temper."

Hongcheon stared at the two old men in turn, his eyes wide.

The name Flame Tiger.

The immense auras radiating from the two old men, who could not have seemed more different.

"Could you two be…?"

Flame Tiger gave a ferocious laugh and nodded.

"You're only realizing it now? You must still be a youngster. All those damned monks of the Beom generation[1439] have been dead for ages… Are you the Dharma King's youngest Junior Brother?"

"…!"

"Judging by that reaction, I guess I'm right. Han Su, what was the name of that old monk you killed at the end?"

"Beomgong."

Hongcheon's fist trembled at the Dharma name of the Martial Uncle who had died during the Great Faction War.

There's no doubt. It's them.

How could he not know the names Flame Tiger and Han Su?

Or the epithet shared by the villains who had killed countless Shaolin disciples?

"The Yin-Yang Twin Freaks."

It was a story from the distant past.

[1439] In Buddhist naming traditions, monks of the same generation may share a character in their Dharma names. Here, that character is *Beom*.

The two demonic fiends had ruled the tropical rainforests of Nanman[1440] and the Great Snow Mountain of the north, respectively. They had emerged into the Central Plains and stained the world with blood, while the orthodox faction's net over heaven and earth, spread to hunt them down, had been torn apart by the Demonic Cult's invasion.

The two fiends had escaped death by the narrowest margin, entered the Demonic Cult's service, and earned a terrifying reputation during the Great Faction War.

"The Yin-Yang Twin Freaks… It has been a long time since I heard that name from someone else's lips."

"Those were good times. Few things have ever been as enjoyable."

Flame Tiger fondly reminisced about that horrific past, then shook his head.

"No, that's not right. I still prefer things as they are now."

"Of course. We couldn't even set foot in Henan back then."

"It was all because of that damned Martial God."

"But the Martial God is gone now."

"Hardly any of those so-called Ten Kings and Three Saints are left, either."

Han Su watched Flame Tiger with a faint smile before abruptly bringing his palms together toward Hongcheon.

"Ah, come to think of it, I'd forgotten for a moment. Please accept my condolences."

Hongcheon, who had stiffened at the appearance of the two old monsters, sensed something ominous and asked:

"Condolences? What are you talking about?"

"On our way up, we heard that someone had died. Dharma King Hong Dao—your Senior Brother."

"…!"

Shock struck him, making the world before his eyes seem to go dim.

His Senior Brother, who should have been at the Murim Alliance, was dead?

That was impossible.

"Nonsense!"

Han Su gave a short laugh as he looked at the shaken Hongcheon.

"Whether it's true or not is for you to decide. And…"

Flame Tiger continued in a heated voice.

"All the monks here, including you, will die. That's our judgment."

Rustle.

As if they had sensed their leader's aura, the masked men took a step forward with emotionless eyes.

A deadly edge rising from hundreds of sword blades filled Shaolin Temple.

[1440] *Nanman* is a historical Chinese term for peoples and regions south of the Central Plains.

Hongcheon’s eyelids trembled at the sight.

Senior Brother… Is it true?

But the trembling soon subsided, and light returned to his eyes.

The old monk, who had devoted eighty years to martial arts, clenched his fists.

“I never thought I’d have to face the Yin-Yang Twin Freaks at the same time. Come, you damned old monsters.”

“Wahahaha! You’ve got quite a foul mouth for a monk. I like that you’re still so full of youthful vigor.”

Flame Tiger burst into hearty laughter and stepped forward.

“Unfortunately, one old man is enough for you. Han Su has a more pressing matter to attend to.”

“Very urgent business.”

Han Su smiled faintly and continued.

“So will you step aside? I have to go to the Face-Wall Cave.”

The Face-Wall Cave.

The moment those words left Han Su’s mouth, Hongcheon felt his heart plummet.

Unnamed was there. His Senior Brother’s only Disciple.

And…

The Green Jade Buddha Staff.

At last realizing the enemies’ objective, Hongcheon let out a lion’s roar.

“Stop them by whatever means necessary!”

“Stop us? That won’t be enough.”

The Yin-Yang Twin Freaks flicked their hands, dark smiles spreading across their faces.

As though they had returned to the days of fifty years ago, horrifying killing intent surged from their entire bodies.

“Kill them all.”

Fwooooooosh!

Chapter 261

Blood gushed up.

The middle-aged monk's beard, streaked here and there with white, was soaked in blood. He forced out the words in a broken voice.

"D-Demon. You're a demon."

A calm voice slipped into his ear.

"Shakyamuni[1441] drove away the demons' temptations and attained enlightenment beneath the Bodhi tree, or so they say. But…"

Shaaak!

A hand wreathed in bitterly cold blue Force pulled free of the monk's chest.

The gaping wound had already frozen over, and frost-covered drops of blood fell to the ground like shards of ice.

"No enlightenment can endure in the face of death."

The monk trembled as a chill swept through his entire body.

He did not know whether it came from the extreme Yin-Cold Technique that had frozen even his internal organs or the aura of death looming before his eyes.

No. He could not know.

Ssslip. Thud.

Yin Ghost Han Su looked down at the monk, who had died with his eyes wide open. His gaze darkened.

That was dangerous. More dangerous than I expected.

He looked around. Four corpses lay sprawled before the collapsed entrance to the Face-Wall Cave, including the middle-aged monk who had just fallen.

The Four Great Vajras.[1442]

As martial monks counted among Shaolin's finest, each of them possessed formidable martial arts.

The last bald monk in particular had been a master at the threshold of Supreme Peak. If Han Su had not traded flesh for bone, he might have lost his life to the Four Great Vajras' combined assault.

Persistent bastards. Somehow, they've managed to keep their lineage alive.

Shaolin had suffered losses approaching ninety percent during the last Great Faction War.

The damage had been so catastrophic that it could no longer compare to the days when it had been called the greatest sect under heaven. Even so, the strength Shaolin had accumulated over a thousand years still remained.

[1441] Shakyamuni is a name for the historical Buddha.

[1442] Vajras are Buddhist guardian figures; the Four Great Vajras is the title of these four elite Shaolin monks.

But that ends today.

Every part of the plan was proceeding smoothly. Dharma King Hong Dao was dead, the Four Great Vajras had fallen, and Hongcheon would soon meet his end at Flame Tiger's hands.

The hundreds of killers stripped of every sensation would drench Mount Song in blood and withdraw only after burning the martial arts manuals in the Scripture Depository.

If Shaolin lost both its leading masters and its martial arts, its decline would be certain.

And one mission took priority over everything else.

The Green Jade Buddha Staff.

Han Su could not guess why Shaolin's sacred treasure mattered so much, but he had to complete his task.

Because it was none other than the Lord of Heaven's command.

Was that not why *he*, the man who enjoyed the Lord of Heaven's absolute trust, had come with them?

"I'll take care of Hong Dao. You bastards take care of Shaolin. If you fail to find the Green Jade Buddha Staff… I'll leave what happens next to your imagination."

Han Su's face stiffened as he recalled the last thing *he* had said.

There could not be a single mistake. If Han Su failed, he would pay dearly for it.

Boom!

Han Su flicked his sleeve, clearing the blocked entrance to the Face-Wall Cave.

Even the massive stone gate revealed beyond it could not halt his advance.

Rumble!

The stone gate collapsed with a deafening roar. Beyond the billowing cloud of dust and powdered stone, a pair of eyes gleamed with piercing light.

"Benefactor. What brings you here?"

Han Su curled his lips as the young monk, Unnamed, unfolded his crossed legs and slowly rose.

"Are you Hong Dao's Disciple?"

"And what will you do if I am?"

"I've come to collect something."

"I have nothing to give you, Benefactor."

"Then let me correct myself. I've come to take it."

"I cannot surrender so much as a single grain of rice to someone reeking of blood."

"Don't trouble yourself over it. I'll take your life along with it."

"Amitabha."[1443]

[1443] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha invoked in Buddhist prayer.

Unnamed brought his palms together, his prayer beads wrapped around one hand. Determination gleamed in his eyes.

"It won't be easy."

The battle between Hongcheon and Flame Tiger, two fist masters who had reached Supreme Peak, was fierce.

Screeeech! Boom!

Every thrust, swing, and rising kick carried tremendous power.

It was a clash between superhumans who had stepped into the lofty realm of Supreme Peak—a battle no one dared interfere with.

But as time passed, the scales began to tip.

Boom!

The instant their Force-wreathed fists collided, a line of crimson blood trickled from one man's mouth.

"Cough."

The monk's gray robes turned bright red.

Flame Tiger bared his yellow teeth as Hongcheon was driven back a dozen steps, as if swept away by an invisible wind.

"Brat. When you were still suckling at your mother's breast, this old man was rampaging through Nanman.[1444] You're thirty years too early to challenge me."

Hongcheon wiped his mouth with his sleeve. Despite his pallid complexion, the old monk's eyes burned fiercely.

"You truly are an old monster. How about climbing into your coffin already?"

"Even when the orthodox faction cast a net over heaven and earth, they couldn't catch this old man. A bald monk like you doesn't stand a chance."

Hongcheon bit his lip as Flame Tiger's aura blazed even more fiercely.

He knew those words were not mere confidence. They were simply the truth.

What kind of monster is he, to still be going this strong?

The Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts had already been over sixty during the Great Faction War.

Yet despite clearly being well over a hundred now, Flame Tiger showed no sign of fatigue.

Internal energy whose depths Hongcheon could not begin to fathom. Experience accumulated through countless acts of slaughter. Even the one weakness Flame Tiger should have possessed—old age—seemed to have passed him by.

Despair closed in around Hongcheon.

[1444] Nanman is a historical Chinese term for peoples and regions to the south.

But there's still hope.

His eyes shifted slightly toward the more than one hundred martial monks fighting the masked men.

One hundred and eight, to be exact.

They were the Hundred and Eight Arhats,[1445] the face and pride of Shaolin Temple.

The carefully selected elite wielded their precept blades and Zen staffs, steadily driving back the masked men.

"They are the greatest criminals under heaven. Show them no mercy!"

"Open the Killing Gate!"

The Hundred and Eight Arhats displayed their true strength when they deployed the Hundred and Eight Arhats Formation.

Each of them performed his assigned role flawlessly, calmly reproducing in battle what they had practiced thousands of times.

Clang-clang-clang! Slash!

The Hundred and Eight Arhats Formation bore down like the palm of the Tathagata,[1446] and the masked men began to fall one after another, spraying blood.

The battle, so one-sided at first, had become evenly matched.

If this continues… we can win.

The Murim Alliance was only a few shichen[1447] away. Once reinforcements arrived, the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts and the masked men would be the ones in danger.

A glimmer of hope crossed Hongcheon's eyes.

"Wahahaha!"

"…?"

"Every thought is written all over your face. What an innocent monk you are."

Hongcheon's expression stiffened. Something about Flame Tiger's attitude struck him as strange.

Did he already know this would happen?

But why?

Before he could pursue the question, a deafening explosion left his ears ringing and shook the earth beneath his feet.

Kwooooom!

Hongcheon stared at the sight before him, his mouth hanging open.

The world seemed to slow. Amid the earth thrown more than ten zhang[1448] into the air, severed limbs tumbled through a downpour of blood.

[1445] An arhat is a person who has attained liberation in Buddhism.

[1446] Tathagata is a title of the Buddha.

[1447] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[1448] A zhang is approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft); ten zhang are approximately 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

One section of the Hundred and Eight Arhats Formation had vanished as though swallowed by a gigantic monster.

“No!”

Time lurched back into motion with Hongcheon’s scream.

The explosion had devastated an area more than ten zhang across. More than twenty Arhat monks had been reduced to chunks of flesh.

The masked men surged into the gap like a wave.

Slash. Slash. Slash!

The Arhat monks were still only human.

Flashing blades filled the vision of those frozen in shock.

The battlefield allowed not a moment of carelessness. The price of hesitation was horrific.

“Aaaaaagh!”

“Junior Brother!”

The Hundred and Eight Arhats Formation, once as solid as an invincible shield, crumbled helplessly. Several old monks belatedly tried to restore it, but their efforts were in vain.

Their opponents were no ordinary men.

They were beings worthy of being called demons.

“The Lord of Heaven has commanded us. Kill the enemy.”

Tss-tss-tss-tss.

As one masked man muttered in a toneless voice, red light seeped from his eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

The Arhat monks stared in stunned disbelief at the bizarre phenomenon they were witnessing for the first time.

“W-What is that?”

“Demonic martial arts! It’s demonic martial arts! Everyone, get away!”

But it was already too late.

The red light swelled until it enveloped the masked man’s entire body, then erupted in every direction, swallowing dozens of Arhat monks and several masked men.

Boom!

An explosion. A deafening roar. Screams.

Severed limbs flew through the sky, and the rain pattering down was red.

Blood vessels spread across Hongcheon’s eyes as he stared blankly at the scene.

“H-How dare you…”

Shaolin was collapsing.

Shaolin Temple, which had stood unshaken even through the Great Faction War, now overflowed with corpses and death.

The young Disciple who had greeted him with a smile every morning lay dead. The Junior Brother with whom he had shared decades of friendship had vanished without a trace.

As the hellscape unfolded before his eyes, blood dripped from his tightly clenched fist.

“This can’t… This can’t be happening.”

Flame Tiger threw back his head and laughed heartily at Hongcheon’s muttering.

“It’s called the Exploding Blood Demonic Art. It’s a damned tricky art, so it’s difficult to master, but it’s perfect for times like this. I brought a couple of them along… and they’re even more useful than I expected.”

“How dare you bastards—!”

Hongcheon shot forward with a cry that was nearly a scream.

A fist wreathed in crimson Force was waiting for him.

Bababoom!

His Body-Protecting Qi shattered, and a barrage of powerful blows hammered Hongcheon’s limbs.

The pain was so intense that his vision went dark. Blood gushed from his mouth, mixed with pieces of his internal organs.

“Gwaaaargh!”

Through his blurred vision, Hongcheon saw Flame Tiger approaching at a leisurely pace.

“You stupid bastard. You spent all those years learning Shaolin’s martial arts, yet you forgot your Unshakable Mind?”

“Cough! Cough!”

It had been an undeniable mistake. No matter what happened, Hongcheon should not have lost his composure. Whatever he witnessed, he should have responded calmly.

His opponent was a monster who had already been considered comparable to the Ten Kings during the Great Faction War.

The best course of action had been to maintain the standoff somehow and buy time.

“You bastard…”

But Hongcheon still forced himself upright, gasping for breath.

Not yet.

If he fell, Shaolin would fall with him. He had to defend this place until his final breath.

For one moment longer. So that even one more person might escape alive.

That was the final duty of an old monk who had devoted his entire life to Shaolin.

“Come.”

Flame Tiger frowned at the fire burning in Hongcheon’s eyes.

“This is why I hate monk bastards. They’re about to die, but they still insist on putting on airs.”

“What would a demonic fiend like you know?”

“I think I know one thing.”

Flame Tiger laughed savagely.

“You’re about to die.”

Whoosh!

Already gravely wounded, Hongcheon could not follow his speed.

In the blink of an eye, Flame Tiger closed the distance and slammed a fist into Hongcheon’s shoulder.

Thud!

The Force behind that single punch tore through flesh and bone.

Hongcheon screamed as everything below his shoulder vanished.

“Aaaaaagh!”

“You damned bald monk. You dare dodge this old man’s fist? Let’s see you dodge this one too.”

Flame Tiger planted a foot on Hongcheon’s head as the old monk writhed in agony.

Even a tenth—no, a hundredth—of his strength would crush Hongcheon’s skull like a watermelon.

“What do people say at a time like this? Ah, right.”

Flame Tiger tapped his forehead theatrically and continued.

“May you be reborn in paradise.”

Grrrrk.

The pressure slowly increased.

Just as death closed in before Hongcheon’s eyes, two voices reached them.

“Take that filthy foot off him. Before I reduce even your filthy spirit to ash.”

“And make your little chili pepper extra crispy.”[1449]

The first voice belonged to an old man. The second was young—shockingly young.

Flame Tiger turned toward the voices, and his face stiffened.

“The Fire King…!”

[1449] *Gochu basasak* is the name of a Korean crispy chicken dish. *Gochu* means “chili pepper” and is also slang for a penis.

Chapter 262

What awaited us when we arrived at full speed was a scene so horrific I could barely look at it.

Corpses. Pools of blood. Ownerless arms and legs…

If the Shaolin Temple I had seen with my own eyes a year ago had been a beautiful painting of a utopian paradise, then what lay before me now was a painting of hell.

These fucking lunatics.

They had clearly been killing civilians and Murim warriors alike, indiscriminately.

Beyond the masked men battling Shaolin's monks, I spotted a red-bearded old man.

"The Fire King…!"

Without taking my eyes off him, I asked, "Know him?"

"No."

"What about the monk pinned beneath him?"

"Hongcheon. Hong Dao's youngest Junior Brother. He's grown a lot since I last saw him."

"…He sure has."

So much that he looked well over seventy.

As I found myself at a loss for words, the old man's blazing gaze swept over us.

"Are you the only ones?"

Jeok Cheongang answered indifferently.

"What if it is?"

"Heh heh. Looks like you've finally found a place to die, old man."

"Even if your head is empty, you should still speak properly. It isn't a place to die. It's a place to kill—and that includes every one of you."

The old man's eyebrow twitched.

"Still as arrogant as ever. You haven't changed."

"Haven't changed? Have we met before?"

"I saw you once from a distance. I regretted for years that we never had the chance to see which of us was stronger."

"What's your name?"

"Flame Tiger! I am the tiger of Nanman[1450]!"

"The Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts? Good. There should be one more, so there's no need to take you alive. I can kill you."

[1450] Nanman is a historical Chinese term for peoples and regions to the south, literally meaning "southern barbarians."

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue.

“You’re one lucky bastard, though. You turned back with the Sanzu River[1451] right before your eyes.”

“Is that so?”

Flames blazed in Flame Tiger’s eyes. At the same time, Fist Force gathered around his rough, rock-hard fist.

I had expected as much, but the old man was also a Supreme Peak master. What was more, he had trained in the same kind of Scorching Yang Qi as we had.

“You arrived much sooner than I’d heard… but that changes nothing.”

Than he’d heard?

For an instant, I wondered how Flame Tiger could have received word so quickly.

Even if he used a messenger pigeon, we should have been faster.

But I had to set the question aside. Flame Tiger was gripping Hongcheon’s head as though he meant to crush it.

Blood trickled from the mouth of the old monk, whose entire body was drenched in red.

“Cough. Cough.”

“Want this monk to live?”

“…”

I felt Jeok Cheongang tense.

More than thirty *jang*[1452] separated us from Flame Tiger. Even Jeok Cheongang could not charge in recklessly. If he did, Hongcheon’s head would be crushed like a block of tofu.

“Put him down. Now.”

Beneath Jeok Cheongang’s calm voice, I could feel rage boiling like lava.

Flame Tiger grinned.

“I heard you were close to that bald monk, Dharma King Hong Dao. I suppose it was true. Did he ask you to look after his Junior Brother before he died?”

“Hong Dao was wiser and more virtuous than any monk I knew. His name does not belong in your filthy mouth.”

“He’s dead either way. Maybe he’s crossing the Sanzu River[1453] right now.”

Jeok Cheongang stared at Flame Tiger, his gaze dark and still, then parted his lips.

“Go on.”

“What?”

“I said go on. Did you truly think that would be enough to shake this old man?”

“Y-You damned old monster.”

[1451] The Sanzu River is a river in Buddhist tradition that the dead cross on their way to the afterlife.

[1452] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1453] The Sanzu River is a river in Buddhist tradition that the dead cross on their way to the afterlife.

Flame Tiger's face flushed red as he shook Hongcheon by the head.

"Are you saying you don't care if this monk dies?"

"I don't."

"W-What?"

"It's regrettable that I can't save him, but Hong Dao did not ask me to look after his Junior Brother. He entrusted Shaolin to me."

Tss-tss-tss-tss!

At that moment, an immense amount of internal energy gathered in Jeok Cheongang's hand. It rapidly took shape, then shot forward like an arrow.

Not toward Flame Tiger, but toward the masked men ceaselessly swinging their swords.

Kwooooooong!

The terrifying mass of internal energy unleashed from Jeok Cheongang's hand plunged straight into their midst.

Like a starving fire dragon, it rampaged through the masked men, devouring and incinerating everything it touched.

Whoosh!

For the first time, emotion surfaced in their otherwise lifeless eyes.

Fear and pain.

"Aaaaaagh!"

"Aaaaargh!"

Flames soared amid horrific screams.

Dozens staggered away with their bodies ablaze. Dozens more were already dead.

The masked men froze at the sight, and the monks' precept blades and Zen staffs flew toward them.

"It's not over yet!"

"Drive out these villains!"

Fwoosh! Slash!

Jeok Cheongang had reversed the situation in an instant. He fixed Flame Tiger with an icy glare.

"If you're going to kill him, do it. Otherwise, put him down gently. You're a bear, you bastard. Stop trying to play the fox."

"Y-You goddamned old bastard!"

Whoosh!

Flame Tiger played the fox to the very end.

He hurled Hongcheon at us and rushed close behind him, plainly intending to use the monk's body as a shield while he struck at the opening.

—You take Hongcheon.

A thread of Sound Transmission pierced my ear.

Jeok Cheongang and I kicked off the ground at the same instant.

Four figures shot toward one another.

I caught Hongcheon while Jeok Cheongang vaulted over him and attacked the fox—or rather, the bear—hiding behind him.

Kwoooong!

I let the pressure wave from their terrifying collision carry me backward.

After sliding more than twenty *jang*[1454], I laid Hongcheon in a nearby patch of grass. Then I charged toward the two Supreme Peak masters locked in a vicious exchange.

Of course, Flame Tiger was not going to stand around chuckling while I joined the fight.

“You bastard!”

Fwoosh—thud!

My knee rang with a sharp vibration as it blocked a foot as thick as a log.

But that was all.

Supreme Peak and Peak were separated by a gulf no amount of luck could bridge.

But I had more than mere luck.

I had heaven’s luck.

The System.

I can handle him.

One-on-one would have been impossible, but Flame Tiger was already struggling just to hold off Jeok Cheongang.

His only mistake was underestimating me.

“I’m confiscating your dentures for four months.”

Flame Tiger’s face turned red enough to burst at the sight of my grin.

“You green little brat!”

“You yellow old geezer!”

“Kraaaagh!”

Flame Tiger threw Jeok Cheongang off and charged at me with a roar.

“I’ll kill you first!”

Whoosh!

A devastating punch hurtled toward me. Even I would not walk away unharmed if I took a strike wrapped in Fist Force with my bare body.

I stepped back, grabbed White Flame from my back, and swung.

Clang!

The punch stopped with a deafening crash.

[1454] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Flame Tiger's eyes grew as wide as lanterns.

"Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?"

"Expensive weapons really are the best. Don't you agree, Old Master?"

Jeok Cheongang did not answer.

Instead, his blue-white fist was already flying toward Flame Tiger.

Kwoong!

The ground shook with the thunderous impact.

The two fists had met perfectly, but one man's fist had its bones crushed and was charred black.

Flame Tiger muttered with a dazed expression.

"H-How?"

"Did you think all who cultivate Scorching Yang Qi were equal?"

Jeok Cheongang's voice was indifferent, but lava burned in his eyes.

Heat that made Flame Tiger's paltry blaze seem insignificant poured from his entire body, pressing down on everything around him.

Flame Tiger groaned.

"The Fire King…"

"That's right. This old man is Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King and eighteenth-generation successor of the Fire Gate Clan."

"That's imposs— Cough!"

As Flame Tiger coughed up blood and tried to flee, I launched myself after him.

"Where do you think you're going?"

Crack!

My foot came down hard, crushing his instep and driving deep into the ground.

A pained groan escaped through Flame Tiger's clenched teeth along with a spray of blood.

The next moment, two streaks of light pierced into his abdomen as his upper body staggered.

Whoosh!

The difference in our realms meant a difference in power, but the martial art we used was the same.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Thud!

The Body-Protecting Qi encasing him like armor shattered.

A fountain of blood erupted from Flame Tiger's gaping mouth.

"Gueeegh!"

Both men were Supreme Peak masters, but the difference between them was vast.

Jeok Cheongang looked down at Flame Tiger, who was panting from his severe Internal Injury.

“Your luck ends here.”

“Cough. W-Wait a moment.”

“I have neither the time nor the reason.”

“I’ll tell you everything! R-Right, Dark Heaven! Everything about Dark Heaven…”

“Didn’t this old man tell you to stop playing the fox?”

Fwoosh—thud!

There was not a trace of hesitation in Jeok Cheongang’s strike.

Flame Tiger’s head vanished. His body swayed for a moment before collapsing into a pool of blood.

I casually wiped the blood splattered across my face and said:

“Wouldn’t it have been better to keep him alive?”

“You don’t reveal important secrets to a bear as stupid as that.”

“Even so…”

“The bear is dead. Now we catch the fox.”

With those cryptic words, Jeok Cheongang turned his head.

More than a hundred *jang*[1455] away, an old man stood rooted to the spot, staring at us.

In his hand was a short staff glowing with green light.

“The Green Jade Buddha Staff!”

“Yin Ghost Han Su. He’s next.”

The next moment, as though he had understood those words, Han Su’s figure shot away at blinding speed.

Whoosh!

Han Su drove his movement technique to its limit.

Behind him, he could feel two auras drawing closer, little by little—ever so slowly.

Damn it!

He had recognized the man at first glance.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

He had never expected that a monster reputed to be among the very first of the Ten Kings would arrive so quickly.

But who is that young man?

The question briefly crossed his mind, then vanished.

[1455] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The brat's identity did not matter.

What mattered was that Flame Tiger, whose martial prowess equaled his own, had died at their hands.

What an idiot. He attacked the Fire King instead of the Thunderbolt Saber King.

Han Su had first met Flame Tiger during the Great Faction War and spent decades at his side, but they were not sworn brothers bound by a Peach Garden Oath[1456]. He had no intention of dying on the same day and at the same hour as Flame Tiger.

Just a little farther. Just a little more!

His mission was complete.

The Green Jade Buddha Staff in his hand was proof. If he could reach the designated location and rendezvous with *him*…

He would survive for certain.

Because *he* was a master beyond even the Fire King's ability to defeat.

Flame Tiger. If that happens, I'll avenge you.

Just as Han Su tightened his grip around the Green Jade Buddha Staff, his face hardened.

This is…!

Another aura was approaching in the distance.

This one was not behind him.

It was ahead.

At first, he thought it might be reinforcements from the orthodox faction, but the aura he sensed this time belonged to only one person. Its momentum was not particularly strong, either.

Damn it. This complicates things.

If anything delayed him, even for a moment, the Fire King might catch him.

Han Su bit down hard on his lip and wrung every last ounce of strength from his body. The instant he burst through the undergrowth—

"Ah!"

A short cry escaped him, his face lighting with joy.

No emotion could compare to the relief of returning from the brink of death.

Han Su called out to *him*, his voice brimming with elation.

"Blood Lord!"

As though by prior agreement, Jeok Cheongang and I stopped at the same time.

[1456]The Peach Garden Oath refers to the famous oath of sworn brotherhood in *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*.

Han Su, who had gone from a desperate fugitive to a swaggering predator, stood waiting for us.

“There they are! The Fire King—that goddamned old man—and the young brat killed Flame Tiger!”

No.

Han Su was no predator.

He was merely a fox borrowing a tiger’s might.

The real predator was the man standing quietly beside Han Su.

I could sense nothing from him, which was strange in itself.

And that made him seem all the more dangerous.

Jeok Cheongang’s reaction was different. His face stiffened as he asked, “Who are you?”

“Your enemy.”

The young man smiled faintly.

“The enemy who killed your most precious friend.”

…What?

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“That makes me the enemy who killed your most precious friend.”

At those words, I froze.

The same thought must have crossed Jeok Cheongang’s mind.

What did I just hear?

For a moment, I couldn’t make sense of it. The words that had come from the unfamiliar young man’s mouth tangled together in my head.

Wait…

He killed Hong Dao? That bastard?

Memories etched deep into my mind surfaced, then vanished.

Jongni Chu disappearing in the middle of the duel. Hong Dao gasping at death’s door. And the four words he had left behind as his final message.

Jongni Chu. Dark Heaven. Unnamed. Buddhist Staff.

What, exactly, had everything I’d seen and heard until now meant?

Where had it all begun, and how had it unfolded?

I stood frozen like a statue, desperately trying to grasp the thread connecting everything. But before I could put my thoughts in order, a dry voice escaped Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

“You… killed… Hong Dao?”

Each word came out separately, strained with restraint, rage, and disbelief.

The young man smiled faintly at Jeok Cheongang and nodded.

“I told you, didn’t I? It was much easier than I expected. I told him I was going to set off a Heaven-Shaking Thunder in the spectator stands, and he followed me without a fuss.”

“Heaven-Shaking Thunder? Had you planted explosives?”

“Ah, that? Of course it was a lie.”

“…What?”

“Why do people lie? Because every now and then, some idiot falls for it.”

Blood dripped from Jeok Cheongang’s fist as he clenched it hard enough to crush something.

“He wasn’t fooled. He allowed himself to be fooled. That was the kind of man Hong Dao was.”

“He allowed himself to be fooled? I suppose that’s possible. He was the damned Abbot of Shaolin, after all. Saying he wanted to prevent even the slightest chance of a massacre would make sense.”

“You bastard!”

“Don’t give me too much grief. I hadn’t planned anything this shoddy, either. But things went wrong where I least expected them to. Of course, part of that was because of…”

The young man’s gaze suddenly shifted toward me.

“The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. You played your part.”

My body seemed to stiffen just from meeting his eyes.

I didn’t know whether it was because of my hostility toward him or because I could sense the overwhelming difference in power between us.

Maybe both.

I bit my lip and glared at the young man.

“What the fuck are you talking about?”

“You barged into the duel, forcing me to move the plan forward by a day. The biggest complication was that bastard, the Always-Victorious Sword Jongni Chu.”

“…!”

That confirmed it.

Jongni Chu had not been the culprit—or even an accomplice.

“Well, everything worked out neatly in the end.”

The young man extended a hand.

Realizing what he wanted, Han Su hurriedly held out an object.

“Shaolin’s sacred treasure—the Green Jade Buddha Staff.”

“So this is the…”

The young man’s long fingers slowly brushed over the softly glowing Green Jade Buddha Staff.

But the next moment, he stared intently at Han Su’s face.

Han Su’s wrinkled hand was still gripping the staff.

“You can let go now.”

Han Su swallowed hard before answering.

“B-Blood Lord, I have one request.”

“A request? Go ahead. You worked hard, so I’ll do my utmost to grant it.”

It was a strange sight—no, a bizarre one.

An old man groveling before a young man who looked young enough to be his grandson.

Even more so when that old man was the infamous demonic fiend who had turned Shaolin Temple into a river of blood.

Who the hell is that bastard?

There were only two possibilities.

Either his status within Dark Heaven was unimaginably high, or he was much older than he looked.

There was also a good chance that both were true.

Whatever the case, Han Su's face brightened at the answer from the young man called the Blood Lord.

"R-Really?"

The Blood Lord clicked his tongue.

"Have you spent your whole life being deceived? You completed your mission perfectly, so a Reward is only natural. But I wonder what kind of difficult request our Senior Yin Ghost is taking so long to bring up."

"It is not that difficult a request."

"But it's difficult for you to handle yourself?"

"…I am ashamed to admit it, but yes."

"Ah. I think I know what it is."

The Blood Lord jerked his chin toward Jeok Cheongang and me.

"You want me to kill those two, don't you? Am I right?"

Han Su nodded, his eyes filled with killing intent.

The Blood Lord let out a short laugh.

"Well, this is unexpected. I suppose the two of you were closer than I thought."

"He was at my side for half my life. Nothing less will satisfy me."

"Loyalty… Well, that's admirable in its own way."

"Kill them as cruelly as possible. I will lend a hand."

"Will that be enough? If the orthodox faction comes swarming in, things will get troublesome. If we want to finish quickly and leave, you'll have to work up a little sweat too, Senior."

"Then?"

"You take the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. I'll take the Fire King. We should be finished within an ildagyeong at the latest."

"You want me to take that young brat? Wahahaha! Very well!"

Their conversation was absurd. They spoke of our lives as though they were objects already tucked inside their pockets.

At the same time, a chill ran down my spine.

He means every word.

The Blood Lord had just declared that he could kill the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, within the time it took to drink a cup of tea.

The way Jeok Cheongang's face had stiffened proved that his words were no empty boast.

—If things turn against us, run.

At the Sound Transmission that suddenly reached my ear, I gave the slightest shake of my head.

A fierce battle was already raging above us. We couldn't expect help from Shaolin.

If I withdrew, Jeok Cheongang would have no choice but to face the concentrated assault of two Supreme Peak masters.

Our best option is to hold out here until the very end.

Jeok Cheongang knew that too.

And yet he had told me to run because he was warmer and worried more than anyone realized.

This time, we might really be in trouble.

I licked my parched lips and tightened my grip on White Flame.

Han Su sneered at the sight.

"Pathetic fool. Do you think that will change anything? Your attainment is impressive enough, but even if you died and came back to life, you could never defeat this old man."

"Go fuck yourself."

I spat a wad of phlegm onto the ground where he could see it.

"Give me a few shichen[1457] of solid sleep in this world, and when I wake up, you'll die by my hand."

"What kind of bullshit is that?"

"If you don't believe me, put it to the test."

"How dare you, you green little brat!"

It was unfortunate.

If I hadn't been in the middle of a battle, and if time stopped completely when I used Logout instead of merely slowing down, I could have used all the time in the world to escape this crisis.

But those thoughts were nothing more than personal wishful thinking.

Now was the time to face reality, not indulge in delusions.

"I'll freeze you alive."

Step. Step. Crack.

Now I understood exactly why that damned old man was called the Yin Ghost.

The ground froze beneath every step he took, and frost settled over the branches.

"What vicious Yin-Cold Qi. But…"

Jeok Cheongang stepped in front of me.

"You dare not lay a hand on my Disciple."

Whoosh!

If Han Su's Yin-Cold Qi was an iceberg, Jeok Cheongang's Scorching Yang Qi was the sun.

[1457] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

If Flame Tiger's martial arts had truly been equal to Han Su's, then Jeok Cheongang's overwhelming victory had been inevitable.

But Han Su looked perfectly at ease.

He knew there was a tiger behind him.

"Blood Lord, I will need you to step in."

"Of course. It's about time we got started."

The Blood Lord tucked the Green Jade Buddha Staff into his robes as carefully as if it were a priceless treasure.

Then he moved.

No—he vanished.

And in the next instant—

Slash! Thump!

A round object flew through the air with a sickening sound and rolled to a stop at my feet.

White hair. Dignified features. A faint smile still lingering around the mouth.

"…!"

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened along with mine.

Han Su, the infamous great demonic fiend and Supreme Peak master known as the Yin Ghost, had been beheaded in a single strike.

By the hand of the ally he had trusted without question.

Unlike us, the Blood Lord—the one responsible for everything—remained perfectly calm.

"Fucking old man. This is why you should never take in rootless trash."

Clicking his tongue, he casually nudged Han Su's headless body.

Splash!

The corpse toppled like a dead tree, spraying a fountain of blood across the ground.

"If you're a sword, act like a sword. Go wherever the person holding you swings you. How dare you…"

Thud! Thud! Crack!

His kicks, loaded with internal energy, tore through flesh and shattered bone.

After repeatedly stamping and grinding Han Su's lifeless corpse beneath his feet, the Blood Lord swept his fallen hair back.

"There are always people who don't know their place. They don't know how strong they are or how far they should stick their necks out. Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, don't you agree?"

…*Me?*

What was I supposed to say?

I hesitated, then answered honestly.

“No. You just look like a crazy bastard to me.”

For a moment, the Blood Lord stared blankly at me.

Then a smile spread across his lips.

“You’re bold for a young one.”

“You’re still a young brat yourself, and you already seem a little unhinged.”

“Thank you for thinking I’m young. I’m older than I look.”

“Not that old.”

“Don’t push it. I’ve lived at least twice as long as you have.”

I looked him up and down in disbelief.

He stood at roughly my eye level, his body perfectly proportioned.

His face made him look like some inexperienced young man in his early to mid-twenties at most.

This went far beyond merely looking young.

But if there was anywhere something like this could happen, it was the Murim.

“What? Surprised I’m so much older than you expected?”

I shook my head.

“No. If that’s true, I was thinking you’re a bastard who really doesn’t act his age.”

“Wahahaha!”

The Blood Lord burst into cheerful laughter.

His behavior, his tone—everything about him was light, almost frivolous.

That only made him feel more dangerous.

Even now, bent over with laughter and his shoulders shaking, he showed not the slightest opening.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been glaring at him as his shoulders shook, suddenly spoke.

“You will regret this.”

“Regret?”

The Blood Lord stopped laughing and frowned.

“Why would I regret it?”

“If you wanted to finish this cleanly, you should not have killed the Yin Ghost.”

“He was a rusty sword. His usefulness had run out, so disposing of him was only natural.”

“A Supreme Peak master is a rusty sword… Then what does that make this old man?”

The Blood Lord stroked his chin.

“You are worth rating highly, Fire King. If the Great Faction War had continued for one more year, you probably would have become one of the Four Saints instead of merely one of the Three Saints.”

“Then it seems my edge has not gone dull yet.”

“You are good enough to be called a fine sword.”

“What would happen if that fine sword were driven into your heart?”

“Who knows… I’m sturdier than I look. I doubt that would draw even a single drop of blood.”

“When Hong Dao died, this old man swore to heaven.”

The Blood Lord smiled faintly as Jeok Cheongang’s gaze grew dark and still.

“Even if his killer were a demon god rather than a human, I would see this vengeance through to the end.”

“That’s touching and all, but…”

The Blood Lord’s smile vanished as he caressed the hilt of the sword at his waist.

“I have a feeling the Fire Gate Clan’s lineage will end today.”

Without taking his eyes off the Blood Lord, Jeok Cheongang asked me:

“What do you think of that?”

“I think his mouth needs a circumcision. It’s been spewing nothing but dickhead bullshit for a while now.”

The smile disappeared from the Blood Lord’s face.

“…You really are an interesting bastard.”

Step.

The Blood Lord took one step toward Jeok Cheongang and me, then suddenly spoke.

“But how long does that little rat over there plan to keep hiding?”

Rustle.

A suspicious-looking figure emerged from the distant grass and scratched the back of his head.

“Benefactor. I’m sorry. I’ve never been this frightened in my life…”

I had never been so happy to see Cheongpung.

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I never expected to be this happy to see that dumpling ghost. At a time when even a cat's paw would have been welcome, Cheongpung's arrival could be an enormous help.

A delighted shout burst from my lips before I knew it.

"Cheongpung!"

"Yes, Benefactor."

As Cheongpung answered hesitantly, the Blood Lord recognized him.

"Oh-ho. I was wondering what kind of rat it was, but aren't you Huashan's Invincible Divine Sword?"

I had hoped otherwise, but it was just as I feared. That was all the Blood Lord knew about Cheongpung's identity.

The duel had revealed that Cheongpung was a disciple of Huashan, but there was no way he knew that Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had raised his youngest disciple like his own flesh and blood.

This was the perfect chance to lull him into carelessness…

"Or should I call you the Sword Saint's Disciple? Perhaps his grandson?"

"…"

Son of a bitch. There was nothing he didn't know.

Then again, Dark Heaven had recruited the Head Elder and planted him there decades ago. The Blood Lord was clearly one of Dark Heaven's highest-ranking members.

It would be stranger if he didn't know.

The Blood Lord gave a quiet laugh at my disappointed expression.

"No need to look so disappointed. That friend of yours joining you won't change anything."

Would you look at this bastard…

Although Cheongpung and I had yet to advance beyond the upper reaches of Peak, neither of us could be compared to an ordinary Peak master.

I had overwhelming stats and extensive combat experience. Cheongpung had innate martial talent and a genius for combining dozens of martial arts as the situation demanded.

And on top of that, we had the Fire King Jeok Cheongang—the greatest of the Ten Kings.

I thought we had more than a fair chance.

"You're underestimating us."

"I'm only stating a fact."

"What?"

“If you wanted to kill me, you should have brought the Sword Saint instead of his Disciple.”

“…You little bastard.”

“There’s only one thing left, then.”

The Blood Lord spoke with casual confidence and beckoned to us with one finger.

“Prove it with your martial arts.”

That was the only thing he had said so far that was actually right.

He was correct. A martial artist had to prove himself through martial arts.

Victory would prove our strength. Defeat would prove our weakness.

“When you meet Yama[1458], tell him the Fire King sent you.”

Whoosh!

Along with his dry, ashy voice, Jeok Cheongang’s figure shot forward. At the same time, a familiar alert pierced my ears.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A sudden Quest, Life-or-Death Crisis, has been generated!

You cannot refuse the Quest. The Quest will be forcibly accepted!

Damn it. What a perfect title for the Quest.

I kicked off the ground and charged. Instead of cursing, I remembered to shout one name.

“Cheongpung! Now!”

Cheongpung flinched, bit his lip, and lunged forward. The blue-steel sword in his hand danced gracefully, tracing plum blossoms through the air.

Fwoosh! Shhhhk!

On a secluded mountain path, Scorching Yang Qi heated the cool breeze as spear and sword tore through the burning air.

Watching us charge from the front and rear, the Blood Lord parted his lips.

“Well, then… Let’s see what you can do.”

Crack-crack-crack!

Jeok Cheongang flicked his hand. Palm force brimming with Scorching Yang Qi burst from his wrinkled palm.

The Flame Divine Palm, already at Great Completion.

[1458] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld.

Just as the Extreme Yang palm technique—said to burn even the soul—was about to engulf the Blood Lord—

Whoosh!

A single gust of wind blew past.

A saber had appeared in the Blood Lord's hand. Its saber force blazed an ominous red, cleaving the Flame Divine Palm's force in two.

Whoom! Boom!

The massive trees lining both sides of the path exploded.

Flames surged into the air amid a thunderous roar, while dirt, roots, and splinters of wood poured down like a sudden rainstorm.

Two streaks of light pierced through the debris.

Whoosh! Shhhk!

A spear and sword shot toward him from the front and rear.

The Blood Lord curled his lips and released his saber. At the same time, his newly freed fists struck the empty air.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded outward, unleashing a violent gale. The viciously thrusting spearhead and the plum blossoms blooming from the sword's tip were both swept away by the wind pressure.

Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung's eyes widened as their bodies were pushed back against their will.

"…Fuck. He's insanely strong."

"H-How can this be?"

Crack.

The Blood Lord rolled his neck and drew his saber back into his hand. He had fended off both men while controlling it with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space.

"Is that all you've got?"

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyelids trembled.

Who would have thought that a single form of the Flame Divine Palm at Great Completion could be defeated so easily? The Blood Lord had not dodged or deflected it.

He had cut it apart.

Jeok Cheongang's heart sank as he realized the Blood Lord was an even greater master than he had imagined.

When he said we should have brought the Sword Saint if we wanted to kill him… That was no empty boast.

His opponent was a master who could easily stand beside the Three Saints.

No—perhaps he was even stronger.

Neither his internal energy nor his enlightenment in martial arts fell short of Jeok Cheongang's own.

And on top of that, the Blood Lord possessed the youthful vigor and strong body needed to unleash both without the slightest loss.

Today, Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled hands seemed smaller and more wretched than ever.

If only I were thirty years younger... No, even twenty...

When his body had been whole, he had lacked enlightenment. By the time he attained that enlightenment, his body had grown too old.

Water inevitably leaked from an old jar riddled with holes.

That was Jeok Cheongang now.

Perhaps this place will become my grave.

The Blood Lord did not miss the shadow that settled over Jeok Cheongang's eyes.

His lips twisted into a sneer, and he snickered.

"Old man. Starting to get the picture? Do you understand the situation now?"

Jeok Cheongang calmly shook his head.

He knew that Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung were watching his mouth. He could not destroy their morale with careless words.

"You talk too much. We have only just begun."

"Maybe you three have. I haven't even started."

"What?"

"I heard the orthodox factions like to prattle on about courtesy and have masters yield three forms to their inferiors. I thought I'd give it a try."

"...!"

The Blood Lord pointed a long finger at each of them in turn.

All three had unleashed one form apiece, making three in total. Just as he had said, he had yielded three forms without taking a single step.

"Now it's my turn to go first. Struggle all you like."

A crimson gleam flared in the Blood Lord's eyes. His sclera flooded bloodred as a vast and hideously ominous qi erupted from his body.

And then—

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

Mount Song trembled.

Shhhhk! Boom!

Streaks of light filled the air in every direction. Blinding flashes erupted amid the ceaseless thunder of explosions.

Dominating them all was a single saber scattering black-red qi.

Boom!

Powerful saber force swept through the air, leaving a pale trail of light in its wake.

Its destructive arc erased everything in its path, knocking aside every attack sent toward the Blood Lord.

Mine included, of course.

Boom!

The spearhead of White Flame rang sharply. The shaft I gripped with all my strength vibrated violently in my palm.

Even though I had poured an enormous amount of internal energy into it, the force was unbelievable.

It was hard to believe such power belonged to a human being.

What a monster.

Gritting my teeth, I twisted around.

Whoosh!

The black-red blade passed within a hair's breadth of my head, slicing off several strands of hair.

The wind pressure alone split my skin, sending blood trickling down my face.

I caught the drops running along the bridge of my nose in my mouth and swung my spear.

"Hah!"

Whirrrrrl!

The spearhead spun fiercely toward the Blood Lord's chest.

Perhaps because I had poured in all the Points I had received as the reward for winning the Star-Array Grand Banquet, my movement and strength had risen another level.

But—

Crack!

The Blood Lord's free hand snatched the spearhead from the air.

It was a bare hand, but not truly bare. Immense black-red internal energy blazed around it.

"That won't be enough."

With those quiet words, he pulled the spearhead toward him with tremendous force.

Then his eyebrows shot upward.

The spearhead that had been trapped in his grip a moment ago was gone.

As if it had never existed.

“You—!”

Before the startled word had fully left his mouth, I had already plunged deep inside his reach.

Inventory Open. Summon.

In the blink of an eye, White Flame—burning hot with Scorching Yang Qi—was back in my hand.

The Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, harder and sharper than anything in the world, tore through his Body-Protecting Qi and pierced the flesh beneath it.

Thud! Boom!

The Blood Lord snapped his sleeve, and a powerful burst of force slammed into my abdomen.

After being driven back ten steps in a row, I saw the Blood Lord’s wide-eyed face—and the fountain of blood erupting from his chest.

I did it.

Only I could have pulled off that attack—and it had worked precisely because I was merely me.

It landed because I had used the System, something no one could possibly have anticipated, and because the Blood Lord had not considered an attack from someone like me worth guarding against.

Now’s my chance.

It was an opportunity that might never come again. Our last lifeline, one I could not afford to let slip away.

I swallowed the blood surging up my throat and shouted.

“Old Master!”

My voice rang across the devastated mountain path. It pierced the air, rode the wind, and reached one man’s ears.

A heated voice slipped between his lips.

“Well done.”

The old man hurtling toward the Blood Lord had transformed into the Fire King.

Fwoooosh!

A colossal blaze erupted from his small body. It burned the air and crushed the wind.

If the Blood Lord’s qi was something so ominous that merely looking at it made one uneasy, then Jeok Cheongang’s was heat itself—as though it could burn the world.

“Son of a bitch…”

The Blood Lord muttered the curse like a groan.

But it was already too late. He might not have known, but I did. I knew what Jeok Cheongang was doing and how much power that martial art possessed.

He had used it only once before and become a legend by killing a thousand members of the Demonic Cult.

Dance of the Fire God and Demon.

At that moment, Jeok Cheongang vanished.

He approached the Blood Lord on light footsteps, as though dancing, while his hands and feet blurred like mist.

Red and blue fire qi filled heaven and earth. It was a beautiful flash of light—and terrifyingly destructive.

“Fire King!”

Whoosh!

At the Blood Lord’s rough shout, black-red saber force mingled with the fire qi. A thunderous roar rang out, as though cliffs were collapsing and the sky itself were being torn apart.

This is…

I could hardly follow the exchange with my eyes. It lasted less than the smallest fraction of a moment, but I still understood.

Hundreds of tremendously powerful attacks had passed between them in that brief instant.

And I knew who had won.

Boom!

A wave of heat swallowed the black-red saber force. Something flashing shot into the sky and plunged deep into the churned-up earth.

A saber.

Its owner was receiving the final blow.

“This old man told you, didn’t he? Even if you were a demon god instead of a human, I would kill you.”

With those quiet words, Jeok Cheongang drove a palm into the Blood Lord’s chest.

Sizzle.

His flesh burned, and his breastbone collapsed. After vomiting a mouthful of blood, the Blood Lord fell to his knees with a hazy look in his eyes.

And… that was all.

Jeok Cheongang gazed down at the Blood Lord’s motionless head. Then his body staggered.

“Old Master!”

“Grandpa Jeok!”

Cheongpung and I rushed over, supported Jeok Cheongang, and carried him to a nearby patch of grass that was still more or less intact.

The Dance of the Fire God and Demon.

No flame burned forever. When the dance ended, the fire went out and the heat faded.

That was why Jeok Cheongang, despite all the long years he had lived, had only ever been able to use it once.

“Well? Wasn’t it just as this old man told you?”

“What are you talking about?”

“The Dance of the Fire God and Demon. Wasn’t it incredible?”

At Jeok Cheongang’s faint smile, I let out a sigh of relief.

Then I smiled with him.

“It was incredible.”

I meant it. Everything about it had been incredible.

Except for the voice that came from behind us the next moment.

“The Dance of the Fire God and Demon… That’s one hell of a name.”

We slowly turned our heads.

The Blood Lord rose to his feet before our eyes, perfectly unscathed.

Chapter 265

I was certain—absolutely certain—that he was dead.

Even if he had not breathed his last, I was convinced he could no longer be called a living human being.

But…

Slither. Crack-crack!

I could hardly believe what I was seeing.

Pale new flesh spread over skin that had been burned black and looked ready to crumble at the slightest touch. Protruding bones slid back into place and disappeared beneath it.

What the hell is this?

What was I supposed to call it? Recovery?

No. This was regeneration.

Regeneration beyond anything human—like something out of a monster.

Cheongpung let out a strangled gasp at the horrifying sight.

“Ah… Aah…”

Meanwhile, the last of the changes came to an end. The face that had been stripped down to the muscle rapidly regenerated.

Crack.

The Blood Lord rubbed his neck and flashed us a crooked grin.

“You should have crushed my head. Made sure of it.”

Jeok Cheongang had gone rigid as a statue. He barely managed to part his lips.

“How?”

The Blood Lord answered casually.

“For now, let’s just call it demonic martial arts. It’s all the same to orthodox bastards like you anyway, isn’t it?”

“You… Cough!”

“Old Master!”

I was startled and hurried to support Jeok Cheongang. His face had gone pale, and a stream of red blood ran down his chin.

This is bad.

Jeok Cheongang had already exhausted all his strength.

Even the Dance of the Fire God and Demon, unleashed by wringing out the last of his power, had come to nothing. The man in my arms was no longer the Fire King, merely an exhausted old man.

“R-Run…”

Jeok Cheongang could not finish. His head drooped.

I hurriedly checked his pulse. It was faint, but still beating.

He's all right for now.

But it was far too soon to breathe a sigh of relief.

"From the look of things, even the great Fire King has reached his limit."

The Blood Lord stepped forward with a delighted expression.

"This was more entertaining than I expected. No, to be honest, it was even frightening. I never imagined things would reach this point."

"You smell like shit. Shut your mouth."

I rose to my feet and tightened my grip on White Flame, which I had set down for a moment.

Jeok Cheongang was already out of the fight. If he used any more strength here… something truly irreversible would happen.

"You intend to stop me alone? How admirable."

"Did you trade one of your eyes for taffy[1459] or something? There are two of us."

The Blood Lord shook his head.

"No. There's only one. I don't count terrified little rats as people."

Terrified little rat?

I turned my head.

Cheongpung stood frozen beside me.

His pupils shook uncontrollably, and the hand clutching his sword hilt trembled violently.

Fear.

That was the only emotion I could sense from him.

"To send a wet-behind-the-ears brat out into the martial world… The Sword Saint spoiled his Disciple far too much."

Step.

The Blood Lord was still more than fifty paces away. But when he took a single step, Cheongpung flinched as though burned and retreated.

This is…

My heart sank.

I knew exactly what it meant.

The path I had experienced myself, the path countless others had walked—Cheongpung was only now beginning to walk it.

Of all times, why now?

It was a growing pain every martial artist and Hunter had to experience, but for the genius standing before me, the timing was unbearably late.

[1459] *Yeot* is a traditional Korean sweet similar to taffy. "Trading an eye for yeot" mocks someone for failing to see what is obvious.

The Blood Lord read the realization on my face and grinned.

"You know it too, don't you? He's already finished. That helplessness he's feeling for the first time. The fear of death. Once those things take hold of you, they're not easy to escape."

"…Jongni Chu."

There was no doubt.

This was because of Cheongpung's duel with Jongni Chu.

Jongni Chu was the one who had planted the seed of fear in Cheongpung. And that seed had sprouted after meeting another powerful figure—the Blood Lord.

"Exactly. I have no idea where that fellow came from, but he did quite a job. He drew the attention of the orthodox factions and even neatly disposed of the Sword Saint's Disciple. Ha-ha!"

My mouth felt gritty, as though I were chewing sand.

Cheongpung was still paralyzed with fear, while the Blood Lord leisurely closed the distance between us.

Damn it.

Fortunately, I still had one final move left.

The problem was that it really was my *final* move.

Even if it succeeded, there was no guarantee what the outcome would be. If it failed, all that awaited us was death.

But I have no choice.

I slowly drew up what little internal energy remained—not even ten percent.

One Annihilation.

My only hope was to pour everything I had into a single strike and crush his head.

I folded up the question *Can I do it?* and burned it away.

I have to. Somehow.

I had to choose certainty over doubt, and desperate resolve over certainty. Only by staking my life on every tiny movement would I have even the faintest chance.

"Young sir."

Click. Clack.

I knew what it was without looking.

Cheongpung's teeth were chattering.

I shouted with all my might.

"Cheongpung!"

He gasped and jerked his head up.

"I won't say this twice. Listen carefully and decide for yourself."

"Y-Yes?"

"You have two choices. First, carry Old Master and run as far away as you can."

“Benefactor!”

“I’m not finished. Second, stop shaking like a fucking coward and fight that bastard beside me with everything you have.”

“…!”

His trembling breath betrayed the turmoil inside him.

Then the feet that had retreated several steps began moving forward again.

Step.

We stood side by side in front of the unconscious Jeok Cheongang.

“Your answer. I haven’t heard it yet.”

“This is my answer.”

“Be honest.”

“I’m scared, Benefactor.”

“Fuck. You’re brutally honest.”

“But I really am scared. I’ve never felt anything like this in my life.”

I kept my eyes fixed on the approaching Blood Lord.

“If you’re that scared, why not run?”

“I don’t know. I just feel like if I run away now… I’ll regret it for the rest of my life.”

That regret.

I knew what he meant.

I glanced at Cheongpung. He was still terrified, and his hands still trembled, but the step he had taken forward was firm. His feet were rooted in place, refusing to retreat.

Yes.

For now, that was enough.

I had just given a small nod when—

“Regret? Run away?”

Twenty paces away, the Blood Lord stopped and laughed aloud as though he had heard the greatest joke in the world.

“What audacious nonsense from a pair of fledglings. I’m the one who decides whether you run. That is the right of the strong and the inevitable fate of the weak.”

“Well, you’re partly right…”

I raised my spear and aimed it at him. White Flame’s transparent spearhead shattered the sunlight into countless fragments.

“But why does every word out of your mouth sound so fucking disgusting?”

“The truth is uncomfortable. Especially for the weak.”

“This won’t do. Open wide, patient. It’s time for your circumcision. It might hurt a little—I’ll be using a spear without anesthesia.”

“Puhahaha!”

“You’re laughing? You think it can’t happen to you? That’s how life gets you. I should’ve known something was up when Mom said we were going out for something delicious.”

The Blood Lord’s smile deepened.

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. The more I see of you, the more entertaining you become. Those bizarre martial arts of yours that I can’t identify, that spirit… I like you.”

“And if you like me?”

“Come under me. I might even spare the Fire King.”

“Why don’t you eat a dick, sir? After today, I’ll never have to deal with a bastard like you again.”

“Someone once said that the first meeting is coincidence, the second is a connection, and the third is destiny.”

“Listen to this son of a bitch, writing a goddamn romance novel.”

The Blood Lord shrugged.

“Perhaps. It isn’t a relationship between a man and a woman, but if we’ve crossed paths twice in this vast world, wouldn’t you call that a connection?”

“Twice?”

For a moment, I didn’t understand.

What the hell was this bastard talking about?

“Did you see me at the Star-Array Grand Banquet or something?”

“Of course I saw you.”

His playful voice continued.

“At Eight Spring Gorge.”

“…What?”

“It was quite a spectacle. Corpses piled into mountains, blood flowing like a river… Watching you take Jin Baekyang’s life was especially memorable. Wasn’t that when they started calling you the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“What are you talking about…”

“Jin Baekyang, the Blade of Flowers. What a useless bastard. At first, he acted as though he would tear out his own liver and gallbladder for us, but as he grew older, he must have developed some pathetic doubts. Ruined the entire job. What incompetent fool recruited such a half-assed bastard? Tsk, tsk.”

I stared blankly at the Blood Lord as he clicked his tongue.

Every word coming from his mouth sounded hollow and alien.

“Oh, what about that Third Rate sect called the Mount Heng Sword Sect? Is it still around? I did hear from one of my subordinates that one of its Sect Leader’s sons

had been killed. I lost interest after Eight Spring Gorge, so I haven't paid much attention."

"…!"

A shudder shot along my spine like a bolt of lightning.

"Then… it was you?"

"I told you."

The Blood Lord's eyes curved into crescents. His next words came in a gentle voice that did not suit him at all.

"The first meeting is coincidence, the second is a connection, and the third is destiny. What do you think? Wouldn't you say you and I have a connection?"

My breath caught.

The bastard standing before me was the one who had started that war.

The Blood Lord saw my expression and roared with laughter.

"Why the long face? Things worked out smoothly thanks to me. The Jin Family of Taiyuan is the foremost family in Shanxi. You became the Fire King's Disciple and even seized victory at the Star-Array Grand Banquet. Shouldn't you thank me?"

I did not answer.

One thought filled my mind.

How many people died again?

I didn't know.

A thousand? Two thousand?

Countless people had died in a Great War that had been meaningless from beginning to end. There had been no true victor or loser.

Martial artists who had merely swung their weapons when ordered died. So did innocent commoners who had nothing to do with the conflict. Even more children were left orphaned by the war.

When the Murim of Shanxi began to reel, the mounted bandits of Gaoyuan ran rampant.

The war had barely ended before the same history repeated itself.

And he expects me to thank him.

I licked my dry, cracked lips. My grip around the spear shaft tightened on its own.

An unknown strength filled my exhausted body.

A stat that did not appear in the System window.

Anger.

"Hey."

"Hmm?"

"That bullshit about once being coincidence and twice being a connection."

I took a deep breath. Without it, I felt as though fireballs might pour from my mouth.

"You and I are different. Let's skip all that and go straight to destiny."

"Destiny?"

"Yeah. The destiny where one of us dies."

Before I had even finished speaking, I kicked off the ground.

The distance vanished in an instant, and his smiling face appeared before me.

One Annihilation.

Gooooong!

The spearhead cleaved through space.

Crack!

"Gaaaaah!"

The young man's arm broke, and white bone burst through his skin.

He screamed at the agony, worse than anything he had ever experienced. Spurting blood splattered across his own face.

The foul reek made bile rise in his throat. The instant he bent over to retch, a thick leg slammed into his abdomen.

Thud. Boom!

"You pathetic fool. I pity the Sword Saint for having a half-wit like you as his Disciple."

The young man—Cheongpung—went flying. He struggled to turn himself over.

It hurt.

He wanted to collapse.

His entire body screamed in pain, and a deep despair weighed upon him.

My body… My body won't listen to me.

In the end, he could not rise. He collapsed, and the vast sky filled his vision.

The sky above Lotus Peak on Huashan had always been clear and beautiful. By day, the clouds gleamed; by night, the stars glittered. Roe deer and rabbits bounded energetically across the mountain.

But…

Why is the sky here so red?

This sky was different.

Red and bleak.

Cheongpung blinked and realized that the tiny blood vessels in his eyes had burst. It was the first time that had ever happened, but he was not surprised.

I've already broken bones for the first time, and I've lost so much blood.

Thinking about his condition made his breathing quicken without him realizing it.

As he lay sprawled on the ground, gasping for breath, a chilling sound pierced his ears.

Whoosh—crack!

“Urk!”

“You bastard!”

Cheongpung turned toward the sound. Two figures locked in a bloody struggle came into view through his tilted vision.

No.

It could no longer be called a fight.

Thud! Thud! Thud!

“Hngh!”

“You’re still not dead? Even after this? Even after this?”

Bam-bam-bam! Crash!

His nose collapsed. His ankle broke, and his shoulder was wrenched out of place.

Once. Three times. Ten times…

Yet no matter how badly he was injured or how many times he fell, he rose again.

He would do the same a hundred times.

That was the kind of man Cheongpung knew him to be.

Benefactor.

But reality was merciless.

The outcome had been decided almost immediately.

Cheongpung did not know what martial art Jin Taekyung had used, but the power of that one strike had been unparalleled. It had shattered the Blood Lord’s Red Blade, infused with Sword Force, and wounded him.

Yet in less than a moment, the Blood Lord regenerated and drove them both into a corner.

“You lunatic… I’ve never seen a more tenacious bastard.”

Everything was about to end.

The Blood Lord shook his head, looking thoroughly appalled. His entire body was drenched in blood as well.

Unlike before, however, his wounds no longer healed. The easy smile he had worn throughout the battle was gone, and he breathed raggedly as he pulled Jin Taekyung’s spear from where it stood embedded deep in the ground.

“Huff, huff… Fine. I’ll kill you.”

Kill.

The moment Cheongpung heard that word, his palm pressed against the ground.

The pain from his broken arm and leg faded, along with the smell of blood.

A strange, floating sensation spread through his entire body.

What is this?

He did not know.

At the end of his staggering steps stood the Blood Lord.

“Huh. What’s this now? Do you want to die too?”

His hands trembled when he met the Blood Lord’s ferocious gaze.

But then he saw Jin Taekyung lying behind him, and the trembling slowly subsided.

“Benefactor… Benefactor.”

“What a pair of lunatics…”

The Blood Lord let out an incredulous, hollow laugh and swung the spear.

Slash!

Cheongpung staggered aside, twisting his body. Blood sprayed from his chest.

It hurts.

But he did not stop.

He did not fall.

The sword hilt had slipped from his powerless grip long ago.

“What the…”

The Blood Lord stared at him in disbelief, then seized Cheongpung’s throat with one powerful hand.

“Ghk!”

“What the hell is wrong with you people? Why are you both so desperate to die first?”

His voice held genuine curiosity.

As his consciousness faded, Cheongpung opened his mouth. A strained voice escaped him.

“Because… I think I’d regret it for the rest of my life if I backed down.”

“That’s your reason? A cowardly bastard like you refuses to retreat for such a pathetic reason?”

The Blood Lord’s killing intent grew even more savage.

But something was strange.

Cheongpung was not frightened at all.

It felt as though he had returned to his days on Lotus Peak. Before he knew it, the corners of his mouth had lifted.

“Hehe. Yes.”

The Blood Lord’s face twisted viciously.

Cheongpung had smiled.

He had smiled while standing before him.

It was impossible.
It was something that should never have happened.
“I heard your last words loud and clear.”
The Blood Lord was about to drive the spearhead into Cheongpung’s chest when—
“You’ve broken free of your shell.”
A clear voice rang out.
A voice exactly like the blue sky over Huashan that Cheongpung remembered.
A voice he felt he finally recognized.

Chapter 266

“You’ve broken free of your shell.”

A clear voice rang out.

Cheongpung thought of the sunlight and blue sky over Lotus Peak. The Blood Lord felt as though his heart had dropped into his stomach.

He had failed to sense someone barely two hundred feet away. He, of all people.

His eyes narrowed at the man walking up the mountain path.

That bastard…

He had a slender build and an approachable face. He looked to be in his mid-twenties at most.

A sword had been shoved carelessly through his belt without a scabbard, its blade covered entirely in reddish rust.

A dry voice slipped from the Blood Lord’s lips.

“The Always-Victorious Sword?”

The young man, Jongni Chu, smiled faintly.

“I was always worried.”

“What?”

“About what kind of storms a fearless, innocent child would face once he entered the martial world.”

“What the hell are you talking about…?”

The Blood Lord was about to continue when realization struck him.

From the very beginning, Jongni Chu’s every word and action had been directed at one person alone.

“But it’s all right now. You overcame it so well.”

His gaze and voice were warm.

At last, a faint smile touched Cheongpung’s lips as he struggled for breath.

Watching that, the Blood Lord let out a hollow laugh.

“Would you look at these two…”

They were treating him as though he did not even exist.

Him—the man who inspired fear and awe in countless people, even within Dark Heaven.

The blatant disregard of these young pups made his grip tighten.

Crack.

“Ghk!”

With the sound of bones twisting out of place, a gush of blood burst from between Cheongpung’s lips.

As Cheongpung groaned in pain and lost consciousness, Jongni Chu's quiet voice reached the Blood Lord's ears.

"That's enough."

Seeing the smile vanish from Jongni Chu's face made the Blood Lord feel considerably better.

He grinned and opened his mouth.

"So now you can finally see me."

"I saw you from the beginning. I merely lost you while chasing your retreating back."

The Blood Lord frowned as he listened.

"Was that you? The fearless bastard who interfered with me?"

"I was one step too late. A regrettable thing."

As Jongni Chu calmly answered, the Blood Lord slowly looked him up and down.

The Always-Victorious Sword, Jongni Chu. He's the one?

Jongni Chu had intervened just as the Blood Lord was about to finish off Dharma King Hong Dao. The rapidly approaching presence had forced him to turn away before he could deliver the final blow.

From what I sensed then, his aura was at least beyond the Ten Kings.

Even the Blood Lord would be in trouble if he were held back inside the Murim Alliance. After withdrawing and leaving the dying Hong Dao behind, that bastard had continued chasing him for quite some time.

He nearly caught me.

Fortunately, the martial art the Blood Lord practiced transcended all common sense.

And yet that mysterious master had been Jongni Chu. The Blood Lord shot him a suspicious look.

"You've already chased me this far. You're quick on your feet."

"Not as quick as you. That movement technique of yours was unlike anything I've ever seen or heard of."

The Blood Lord's eyes narrowed.

His opponent was absurdly young. He also seemed close to Cheongpung, and his realm of martial arts was almost impossible to believe.

"You. What is your relationship with the Martial God?"

Jongni Chu stroked his smooth chin, as was his habit.

"The Martial God… I did receive a few teachings from him."

"Are you his Disciple?"

"Even a suckling infant can teach us something. Everyone we encounter in life is both teacher and student to one another."

"Enough with the vague Zen riddles. Answer me before I break this brat's neck."

Instead of answering, Jongni Chu merely regarded him with calm eyes.

They were deep enough to draw a man in forever, yet tranquil as a lake on a windless day.

What is this feeling?

It was strange. They had only met each other's eyes, yet the Blood Lord could not make his hand tighten.

No—it felt as though the strength were slowly draining from his fingers. As if something invisible had seized his wrist and refused to let go.

This is almost like…

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth as the thought surfaced.

No.

That was impossible. How dare he think of *that person* while looking at some worthless orthodox-faction stray?

It can't be. All I have to do is cut down a bastard like him in one stroke.

He forced himself to regain his composure, but an inexplicable unease was already growing inside him.

Could he truly defeat this man?

Could he escape this place?

The Blood Lord slowly licked his parched lips.

"You… Who the hell are you?"

Dark Heaven's information network stretched wide and ran deep throughout the land. Yet it had failed to uncover the identity of one person: Jongni Chu.

A mysterious figure whose face and origins were entirely unknown.

Jongni Chu tilted his head.

"Is that important?"

"What?"

"If a few words could persuade you to stop, I would tell you. But you won't stop."

His tranquil voice continued.

"There are people hovering between life and death even now. If you refuse to stop on your own, I have no choice but to stop you by force."

Shhk.

With that, Jongni Chu drew the sword shoved carelessly through his belt. As the hopelessly rusted blade emerged, a sneer curled the Blood Lord's lips.

"You'll stop me? With that thing that barely qualifies as a sword?"

"Well, it still seems more useful than one might think."

"Have you ever cut anyone with that sword?"

"Countless people. They aren't memories I take much pride in."

“Don’t compare me to some pack of nobodies. Who was the last person you cut down? A bandit no better than a slash-and-burn farmer? Or perhaps…”

At that moment, a low voice slipped from Jongni Chu’s lips.

“The Heaven-Poison Demon Lord.”

The Blood Lord went rigid.

The Heaven-Poison Demon Lord.

No martial artist could fail to recognize that title.

During the Great Faction War, he had been the greatest of archfiends, sweeping across the land while worshiping the Heavenly Demon—the Cult Leader of the Heavenly Demon Divine Cult—as a god.

He had been second-in-command of the Demonic Cult, which had once devoured half the world.

That was the Heaven-Poison Demon Lord.

But even he had been unable to escape the fate of a mere martial artist.

One day, after his evil reputation had grown darker with every passing day, he encountered a certain person. The Heaven-Poison Demon Lord met his death that day, and the one who killed him gained a new name.

“The Sword Saint…!”

The Blood Lord trembled as though struck by lightning.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

That name had briefly crossed his mind when he tried to guess Jongni Chu’s identity. But he had soon shaken his head.

It was impossible.

It could not be allowed to be true.

A strained voice finally escaped his lips.

“You… How could you…?”

Jongni Chu—or rather, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak—ran his fingers along the blade as he answered.

“When the Great Faction War ended, I found myself wondering what I should do next. It didn’t take me long to decide. I simply loved martial arts.”

Scrape. Scrape.

Each pass of the violet Palm Force coating his hand stripped away the reddish rust, revealing the clear blade beneath.

“I devoted myself ceaselessly to martial arts. The child I took in late in life, who was like a grandson to me, became my Disciple—and at times, my teacher as well. Just when I thought I had reached Great Completion, I saw another wall before me.”

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

The great martial artist, who had already reached an exalted realm decades ago, had once again stepped into a new domain.

For a man already prepared in every way, a higher enlightenment had arrived.

“Even I didn’t expect to be Returned to Youth. In any case, finding myself unexpectedly young again made me curious about the outside world. I also found myself thinking about that aggravating grandson of mine who ran away a year ago.”

And so Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had entered the world and traveled throughout the land under the name Jongni Chu.

He was already a figure from the distant past. No one suspected that Mae Jonghak had returned to the body of a twenty-year-old.

Not even Dark Heaven, whose web stretched across the land.

“It was an enjoyable time. Until you people appeared.”

Shhk!

The last traces of rust peeled away.

At last, his cherished sword regained its true form and gleamed coldly.

Hundreds—perhaps thousands. The sword that had drunk the blood of countless fiends now pointed at the Blood Lord.

“Just as I said, isn’t this sword still useful?”

The next instant, a violet flash erupted.

Slash!

“…Huh?”

The Blood Lord blinked.

Time seemed to slow as Cheongpung’s body toppled into view.

So did a familiar wrist—the one attached to the hand gripping the unconscious Cheongpung’s throat.

That’s…

My hand.

The next thought was drowned beneath a surge of blood and pain. His mouth dropped open, and a scream tore from it.

“Gaaaaah!”

But it was not over yet.

As the Blood Lord staggered backward, screaming, a cold voice pursued him.

“You’ve accumulated sins that can never be washed away. Shouldn’t you pay the price?”

Whoosh!

Every hair on the Blood Lord’s body stood on end.

It was like a hallucination. The entire landscape vanished, and a single sword aimed at his chest consumed his every sense.

Shhk.

The sword glided through the air. The violet Force of the Zaha Divine Technique transformed into thirty-six plum blossoms that scattered in every direction.

At the beautiful sight, the Blood Lord murmured as though groaning.

“The Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords.”

But it was different.

Unmistakably different.

If the Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords Cheongpung had used earlier were a supreme technique, what Mae Jonghak now displayed was a divine feat beyond martial arts.

That very divine technique was boring into the vital points throughout the Blood Lord’s body.

I can’t stop this.

Horrified, the Blood Lord tried to throw himself aside.

Grab!

A hand clamped around his ankle.

Jin Taekyung, whom he had thought spent and unconscious, grinned up at him through bloodstained teeth.

“Where do you think you’re going, motherfucker?”

“You—!”

Papapapapat!

The rest of his words never came.

Violet flashes filled his eyes. Blood sprayed, and flesh split apart. The immense agony wiped his mind blank.

“Ghk!”

This was on an entirely different level. There was no way to block the Sword Energy hurtling across more than a hundred feet.

Slash! Slash!

Then, as his consciousness began to fade, the Blood Lord’s eyes suddenly flashed.

No. If I use that—if I use that, I can survive.

His mission was already complete. The Green Jade Buddha Staff in his hand—the only one left—was proof of that.

It was regrettable that he had failed to kill the Fire King, but…

As long as he lived, there would always be another chance.

He glared at Jin Taekyung with a resentful gaze. Even as he vomited clots of blood, Taekyung was smiling.

“Just you wait. I’ll kill you with my own hands.”

“What?”

“Stay alive until then. Make sure of it.”

The Blood Lord’s lips curled upward.

Mae Jonghak, who sensed what he intended, stiffened and sent Sword Energy flying with a rigid expression.

“Stop!”

Shriek! Slash!

The Blood Lord’s one remaining arm was severed cleanly at the shoulder.

“Lord of Heaven!”

Whoosh!

With that shout, he drew upon the last of his strength and shot forward like lightning. His teeth clamped down hard on his own severed arm—or rather, on the Green Jade Buddha Staff it still held.

And then—

Fwoom!

A black radiance, ominous even to behold, swallowed his entire body.

Then it vanished without a trace, taking the Blood Lord with it.

As though it had never existed in the first place.

Chapter 267

Fwoom!

I merely blinked at the black light that exploded like a flash.

That was all…

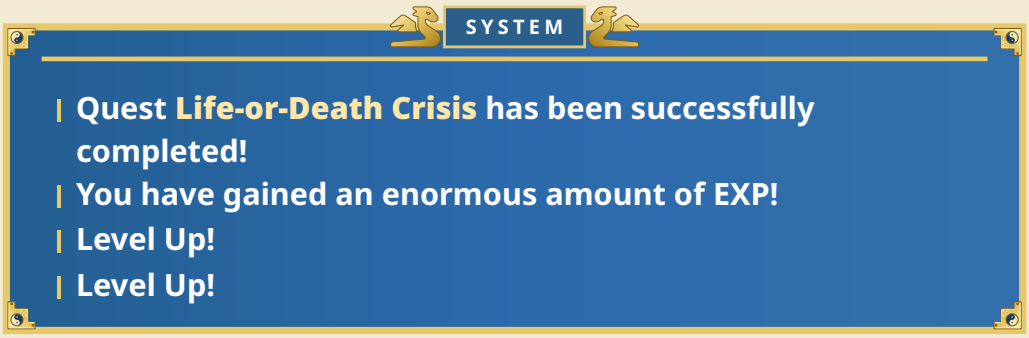
Where the fuck did that bastard go?

The shock was enough to make me forget the pain. I stared blankly, my mouth hanging open.

He was gone. As though he had been erased with an eraser.

The blood spattered around us and the Blood Lord's wrist, still gripping Cheongpung's neck, were the only proof that he had ever existed.

Ding.



With the System notifications, my body began to recover at a staggering rate.

My broken bones knitted back together, and my cut and mangled flesh healed. My empty dantian filled to the brim, and vitality surged through my muscles.

But one thing remained unchanged: my utter bewilderment.

"What the actual fuck was that?"

The Blood Lord. No matter what it took, I should have killed that bastard.

I was muttering dejectedly while staring at the ground when a familiar voice spoke, and a hand suddenly appeared in front of me.

"Are you all right?"

I was mentally exhausted, but my body was fine. I took Jongni Chu's hand and rose to my feet.

"Yeah, I'm fine. I owe you my life."

"That's a relief. Then help me tend to the injured first… Wait. What did you just say?"

Jongni Chu blinked.

His face clearly said, *What did I just hear?*

"Why?"

"H-Hm?"

"Is there a problem?"

Jongni Chu stared blankly at me for a moment, then waved it off.

"No, no. What problem could there be? But didn't you hear… that thing earlier?"

"That thing? What are you talking about? I did pass out for a moment."

There was a limit to how much punishment I could take. I had been hit, gotten back up, been knocked down again, and gotten back up dozens of times over.

Then, at some point, I took a direct blow to the jaw and briefly lost consciousness.

"When I opened my eyes, it was almost over. I saw that bastard's ankle, so I grabbed it right away."

"…I see."

Jongni Chu's lips moved as though he wanted to say something, but he ultimately kept his mouth shut.

I wanted to ask how everything had unfolded and who Jongni Chu really was, but I held back too.

What matters is that he's on our side.

That was enough for now. More urgent matters surrounded us.

"Old Master!"

I was worried about Cheongpung, but Jeok Cheongang was old, and his injuries concerned me even more.

I rushed over and examined him. His pulse was faint and his breathing shallow, but both were still there.

"Would you step aside for a moment?"

After carefully lowering Cheongpung, whose emergency treatment he had finished, Jongni Chu placed a hand over Jeok Cheongang's Mingmen acupoint.[1460]

As internal energy flowed into him, the strain visibly eased from Jeok Cheongang's face.

"How is he?"

"His injuries aren't that serious. He expended too much energy all at once, so he probably won't regain consciousness for a while."

"What about Cheongpung?"

"The same. He has internal injuries, but he's young. He should recover soon."

"Phew…"

"A blessing amid all this misfortune."

Jongni Chu smiled faintly at my relieved sigh.

That was when—

Shshshshk!

[1460] Mingmen, meaning "Gate of Life," is an acupoint on the lower back.

Countless presences rapidly approached from below. Their aura was vicious beyond description.

Don't tell me there's another one?

My expression hardened as I tightened my grip around the spear shaft, but Jongni Chu waved a hand.

"Put it down. They're allies."

He was right. Hundreds of martial artists soon appeared, with several familiar faces leading them.

Someone from the Nine Sects and One Gang. Someone from the Five Great Families.

They were the people who had occupied the seats of honor during the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

For some reason, however, several key figures—including the Thunderbolt Saber King—were nowhere to be seen.

"Stop."

The footsteps of the hundreds of martial artists, which had seemed as though they would never stop, came to an abrupt halt in front of us.

The man who had given the order limped toward Jongni Chu and me. Sunlight filtering through the leaves glinted off his steel prosthetic leg.

The Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho.

As his piercing gaze swept over Jongni Chu and me, I suddenly remembered something I had forgotten.

They didn't know Jongni Chu was an ally. To them, he was a public enemy of the Murim who had assassinated Dharma King Hong Dao and brought a bloodbath down upon Shaolin Temple.

Step. Step.

As the Thousand-Faced Fox advanced on his prosthetic leg, hundreds of martial artists moved with him.

This looked like it was about to turn into a bloody clash over a stupid misunderstanding.

"W-Wait a second. I think there's been a serious misunderstanding…"

I was about to step forward amid the ominous tension when Jongni Chu suddenly spoke.

"Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho."

"Gasp."

Was this bastard insane?

At a time when explaining the situation and clearing up the misunderstanding should have been the bare minimum, he had started by speaking informally.

"Hey, hey!"

I hurriedly jabbed him in the side, but it was already too late. A bombshell burst from Jongni Chu's mouth.

"How's your leg?"

"…!"

Was he actually out of his mind?

I gaped at Jongni Chu.

This time, he had crossed the line completely. First the casual speech, and now he was mocking a disabled person.

I hurriedly stepped forward before the Thousand-Faced Fox could yank off his prosthetic leg and charge at Jongni Chu.

"I'm sorry. He's not usually like this. Let me explain. So, what happened was—"

"Hm? I can explain it myself."

"Explain, my ass. What the fuck are you going to explain in this situation? Apologize first, you bastard."

To hell with him being my lifesaver.

Before things could get any worse, I grabbed Jongni Chu by the back of the neck and forced his head down.

When I raised my own head, I saw the Thousand-Faced Fox's face, stiff and frozen as though he had seen a ghost.

He's really pissed.

Of course he was. Anyone who didn't get angry in this situation wasn't human. They'd have to be Jesus or Buddha.

But the thoughts racing frantically through my mind as I tried to defuse the situation ground to a halt at the Thousand-Faced Fox's reply.

"It has been a long time."

Jongni Chu nodded with a genial chuckle like an old man.

"It's good to see you doing well. I thought you would be the first to recognize me."

"It took me quite some time. Until two shichen[1461] ago, I thought the Blood Ghost Sword Demon—that damned bastard—had Returned to Youth."

"My, my. You've grown old too."

"I owe the fact that I lived long enough to grow this old to you, Great Hero. If you hadn't saved me back then, I wouldn't be standing here now."

The Thousand-Faced Fox laughed as he lightly tapped his prosthetic leg, then continued.

"I discovered Shadow Killer two shichen[1462] ago. You were playing a mischievous prank."

"Ah, that fellow. Come to think of it, he should be waking up around now."

[1461] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[1462] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"Someone who should have died was alive. That was when I realized I had been barking up the wrong tree."

"I didn't want anyone to find out. I wanted to keep it hidden until the Star-Array Grand Banquet ended, at least."

Jongni Chu added with a bitter expression,

"I never imagined something like this would happen, though."

"I feel the same. Despite all our precautions, a bloodbath occurred at Shaolin of all places…"

"You wouldn't be here unless the situation at Shaolin had been settled. Did the Thunderbolt Saber King go?"

"Yes. As soon as we grasped the situation, we divided our forces and took two separate routes. Great Hero Peng should be handling matters at Shaolin by now."

"The losses are too great. Something that should never have happened has happened."

"I have much to tell you about that."

"As do I."

A heavy silence settled over us.

I had been listening to their conversation in a half-dazed state, but somehow managed to speak.

"Hey, no. Excuse me."

Jongni Chu—or rather, *he*—blinked.

"Are you talking to me?"

"Yes. Um, there's something I'd like to ask you…"

"Ask me anything."

Hundreds of pairs of eyes turned toward me. Everyone wore the same expression.

That lunatic has finally come to his senses.

"May I ask your name?"

The answer came without hesitation.

"Mae Jonghak."

"…Ah. Mae Jonghak."

Every hair on my body stood on end.

From our first meeting to this moment, every conversation I'd had with him and everything I'd done flashed rapidly before my eyes.

"I think it's a coincidence, but your name is the same as someone I know."

"Is that so?"

I drew a deep breath. My heartbeat thundered in my ears.

It's cold.[1463]

A dagger had flown straight into my chest. But don't worry. There were more people with the same name than you might think.

Maybe he was Fake Jonghak.

Clinging to that final hope, I opened my mouth.

"Do you happen to have an epithet…?"

"The Sword Saint."

"Ah. Yes."

Fuck. He's the real thing.

As darkness swallowed my vision, an amused voice slipped into my ear.

"Let's remain good friends from now on. Friend."

"…"

I want to die.

An enormous cavern of unknown depth in an unknown location.

At its center, where complex patterns and characters no one could decipher had been carved into the stone, black radiance erupted.

Whoosh!

The deep darkness stretched, dimming even the fiercely burning torches.

When the pitch-black darkness vanished a moment later, unrest spread among the dozens of black-clad figures surrounding the cavern's center.

"The Blood Lord!"

"What is going on…?"

Their gazes converged on a staggering, bleeding figure.

A young man drenched in blood and breathing heavily.

Sword wounds covered the Blood Lord's entire body, and blood gushed nonstop from the severed stumps of both arms.

"Call the sorcerers! Bring them here!"

"The Blood Lord is gravely wounded!"

As the desperate shouts echoed through the cavern, the Blood Lord slowly opened his mouth.

The severed arm he had held on to until the very end dropped to the floor with a thud. Its hand still clutched a short staff.

The staff gave off a faint green light even in the darkness, drawing a quiet gasp from someone nearby.

[1463] The lines about a chill and a dagger in the chest parody a well-known line from the Korean film *Tazza: The High Rollers* (2006).

“The Green Jade Buddha Staff…!”

It was none other than the sacred treasure of thousand-year-old Shaolin.

No one had been able to guarantee the mission’s success. Yet despite the wretched state he had returned in, their superior had completed it splendidly.

Just as expected of the Disciple cherished by *that person*.

“Congratulations!”

“Congratulations?”

A red glow filled the Blood Lord’s eyes as he stared at the subordinate bowing deeply with a fist-and-palm salute.

Whoosh—crack!

The subordinate’s chest shattered, and he slammed into the wall amid a fountain of blood.

His body trembled with a wheezing sound, then went still. There was no need to check. He was dead.

“Throw that bastard to the beasts.”

The moment the Blood Lord’s frigid voice left his lips, one of his subordinates hoisted the corpse over his shoulder and disappeared.

This was hardly the first or second time such a thing had happened. They were merely reminded once more of how terrifying their superior was. Not one of them mourned or showed any agitation over the death of the ignorant newcomer who had stepped forward.

“Blood Lord, you must receive treatment first…”

“I’m dizzy. Begin.”

The Blood Lord surrendered himself to the sorcerers who had just arrived.

He wanted to slaughter everything in sight, but barely managed to suppress his murderous impulse.

He needed to conserve his strength for now. He had to recover as quickly as possible so he could tear those bastards apart and kill them.

The Sword Saint. The Fire King. Cheongpung. And…

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung.

The memory of that bastard grinning through blood-soaked teeth made his blood boil.

Unable to contain his rage, he smashed a fist into a sorcerer’s head.

Boom. Thud.

The headless body collapsed like a rotten old tree. Feeling the frightened gazes of the remaining sorcerers, the Blood Lord spat through clenched teeth,

“I can’t afford to kill any more valuable sorcerers. Continue.”

The treatment resumed after its brief interruption. It was a bizarre sight that defied explanation. Broken bones knitted together, and flesh grew back.

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth against the pain that accompanied the recovery. As his vision began to turn white, one man’s face appeared before him.

You… I’ll kill you with my own hands. I swear.

Chapter 268

The death of Dharma King Hong Dao. And the mysterious bloodbath at Shaolin Temple, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper[1464] of the Murim.

Word travels faster than a galloping horse.

Countless eyewitnesses spread the rumors far and wide.

“Did you all hear the news? About the Star-Array Grand Banquet…”

“Martial artists are surrounding Mount Song. I heard there was a bloodbath at Shaolin Temple.”

Henan Province, which had been swept up in the festive excitement of the Star-Array Grand Banquet, was thrown into an uproar.

The elderly recalled the Demonic Cult’s rampage across the land several decades ago. The young realized that the war they had dismissed as a dusty relic of the past had become a present-day reality.

“The Demonic Cult has appeared? This is terrible. Just terrible.”

“I heard someone else was behind it, not the Demonic Cult.”

“You’re saying there are others besides the Demonic Cult capable of such a thing?”

“I don’t know the details myself. It’s just something I overheard.”

“That can’t be right. They say the terrifying Yin-Yang Twin Freaks led the attack on Shaolin.”

“The Yin-Yang Twin Freaks? I heard the Heavenly Demon of the Demonic Cult personally made a move.”

“T-The Heavenly Demon?”

As one rumor piled onto another, the story snowballed.

With everyone lost in a jumble of truth and lies, it was only natural for their attention to turn toward a single place.

The former site of the Murim Alliance.

The place where the great and small pillars of the orthodox faction stood.

“I heard what happened. About Jongni Chu—or rather, Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint.”

“…”

“Keep your chin up. These things happen.”

“…”

“I’m completely broke myself now. Whew… Anyway, that’s what happened to me. But when I heard your news, Captain, I felt strength surging through me.”

[1464] “Mount Tai and Northern Dipper” is an East Asian honorific for a preeminent authority.

"Why?"

"Pardon?"

"I asked why that gave you strength."

"Isn't it obvious? As the ancient sages said, pain grows lighter when shared…"

Thwack!

"Guh."

A precise blow to the solar plexus folded Hyuk Mujin at the waist and knocked the wind out of him.

When I saw the back of his head sitting wide open, my hand moved on its own. It just moved.

Smack!

"Feeling stronger now? Huh?"

"W-Wait. You hit me in the solar plexus. The solar plexus."

"You're making my blood pressure shoot up, you bastard. You've got my blood running backward!"

Smack-smack-smack!

After raining blows down on the back of his head, I finally felt a little better.

I already had enough on my mind. Why did this bastard have to rile me up on top of everything else?

"Things are serious right now, so watch your mouth. Got it?"

Rubbing the back of his head, Hyuk Mujin muttered, "You looked too serious, so I was trying to lighten the mood."

"Just keep quiet."

"…Yes, sir."

Having silenced Hyuk Mujin, I gazed out the window.

Martial artists hurried frantically in every direction. Though none of them openly showed it, tension hung thick in the air.

Yet amid it all, the sky was brilliantly clear.

Hyuk Mujin's subdued voice reached my ears.

"It feels strange."

"What does?"

"Everything. None of it feels real. It's only been one day."

"I feel the same way."

Even *tumultuous* wasn't enough to describe it. Nothing that had happened the day before felt real. It all seemed like a dream.

Hong Dao breathing his last. Shaolin Temple drenched in blood. The Yin-Yang Twin Freaks, the Blood Lord, and finally Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

The scenes passed before my eyes like a panorama.

The problem is, this is only the prologue.

If this were a movie theater, it wouldn't be strange for the end credits to start rolling by now. But this was nothing more than an ominous prelude.

The vague sense of crisis that everyone anticipated was so palpable I could feel it on my skin.

Something is changing.

The world had already become a massive powder keg. The orthodox faction held the fuse, but Dark Heaven had the flint.

And just yesterday, the fuse had been lit.

I didn't know how all this would end, but I could guess what would happen along the way.

There's going to be a war.

A war on an entirely different scale from the one in Shanxi Province.

There was no way the people at the top had failed to realize what even I suspected.

The leaders of the orthodox faction were already consumed with handling the aftermath and holding meetings about the incident.

"Come to think of it, Captain, didn't you attend yesterday's meeting too?"

I nodded slightly.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan might not compare to the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families, but it was still the undisputed hegemon of Shanxi Province.

And since Shanxi Province was where Dark Heaven had first revealed itself, it was only natural that the leaders would take a keen interest in it.

"What did they say?"

"They asked about the Head Elder and the Red Wind Band. I told them everything I knew."

"The Head Elder is one thing, but why the Red Wind Band?"

"The Temporary Strength Pill used by Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader, is connected to Dark Heaven."

"Ah."

Hyuk Mujin was now a high-ranking member of the family, so he had some idea of what was going on. He knew about both the Temporary Strength Pill and Dark Heaven.

"Did they say anything else?"

"I just left. My eldest brother will hear the important news and pass it on anyway…"

My voice sank without me realizing it.

"I didn't feel comfortable leaving Old Master alone for too long."

My gaze drifted from the window toward a lone figure.

A small elderly man lay on the bed as though deeply asleep.

When I took his wrinkled hand, I could feel his pulse. The faint rise and fall of his chest told me he was breathing. But even after a full day, he still hadn't regained consciousness.

"When do you think he'll wake up?"

"That's the problem. No one knows."

"Didn't some famous physician come by?"

"He said there was nothing he could do. Since Old Master wasn't gravely wounded like the others, he told us to wait and see."

The Dance of the Fire God and Demon. The supreme technique of the Fire Gate Clan.

It possessed enough power to contend with a thousand martial artists, but everything came at a price.

A man well over a hundred years old simply didn't have the stamina or strength left to withstand the aftermath.

Maybe…

I shook my head, driving away the thought that had suddenly surfaced.

There was no point dwelling on the worst.

Both the Sword Saint and the physician had said his life wasn't in danger. For now, the best thing I could do was stay by Jeok Cheongang's side and watch over him.

"There weren't any suspicious people around while I was gone, were there?"

The Abbot of Shaolin had been assassinated inside the Murim Alliance. No one was safe. Just as Jeok Cheongang had protected me from the Blood Lord, I had to protect him.

Hyuk Mujin nodded confidently.

"The Jin Dragon Squad has the pavilion completely surrounded. No one can slip through. Don't worry."

"The Jin Dragon Squad? The elite force of the Taiyuan Jin Family?"

"Yes. The Lesser Family Head was concerned for Great Hero Jeok's safety, so he assigned me here. Who do you think I am? I'm Hyuk Mujin, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad."

"Uh…"

I looked him up and down, then quietly averted my eyes.

Hyuk Mujin's confident expression instantly turned sour.

"What was that reaction?"

"Nothing. I just realized I shouldn't leave again."

"Don't tell me you don't trust the strength of the Jin Dragon Squad, the family's finest?"

"Come on. I said that's not it. Let it go."

Hyuk Mujin glared at me through narrowed eyes, then shot to his feet.

“Fine. I’ll report to the Lesser Family Head and have everyone withdrawn.”

“Hey, why are you taking it that way? Are you going through puberty or something?”

“Because you keep saying such hurtful things, Captain! Is this only the first or second time? Huh?!”

“Keep your voice down. You’ll wake Old Master.”

“It would be nice if he woke up.”

“…”

He had a point.

As I found myself momentarily at a loss for words, Hyuk Mujin headed for the door.

One glance told me he was putting on an act because he wanted me to stop him. At times like this, I had to give him what he wanted.

“Hey, where are you going?”

Hyuk Mujin huffed, “Forget it. I can put up with anything else, but I won’t tolerate you insulting the subordinates I care about!”

“Gasp.”

“What now?”

“I never thought I’d hear words like that come out of your mouth. Mujin, you’ve really grown up. Guess your mouth doesn’t need circumcising after all.”

“…I’m really leaving.”

“Fine, fine. Sit down. Calm down and have a glass of water.”

“Hmph. No.”

“Well, well. Our Mujin really has grown up. Making me say it twice now.”

“…!”

Hyuk Mujin froze, then quietly lowered himself onto the chair.

“I still deserve an apology.”

“Huh? For what?”

“For insulting my subordinates.”

“Why should I apologize? I never insulted them.”

“You just said you didn’t trust them. Wasn’t that because you look down on them for being weaker in martial arts than you?”

I sipped my cold tea.

“Well, we’re not the Nine Sects and One Gang or one of the Five Great Families, so of course there’s a difference in strength. But you said every member of the Jin Dragon Squad is young and talented, didn’t you? They distinguished themselves yesterday too. Weren’t they the ones who saved Unnamed?”

Shaolin was a mighty tree. Yesterday's tragedy had cost it a great branch called the Dharma King and countless fruits, but its roots remained.

Shaolin's martial arts. And Unnamed, who had survived.

Those were its roots.

Oh, and hadn't they said that old monk Hongcheon survived too?

"That's right. They fought Dark Heaven without giving an inch."

Hyuk Mujin puffed out his chest, his face filled with pride.

"Exactly. Then what's the problem? The kids looked sharp to me. They're fiercely loyal to the family too. There's only one problem."

"What's that?"

"You're their Vice Squad Leader."

"…"

"Your subordinates are standing at attention down there, while their Vice Squad Leader sits up here shooting the breeze?"

"Th-That's…"

"You said you cared about them. That you were proud of them."

"It's true! Do you have any idea how much I care about those guys…?"

Hyuk Mujin faltered for a moment, then quickly recovered and poured out the words as though he had been waiting for the chance.

"Besides, my current mission is to guard Great Hero Jeok and you, Captain."

"And before that?"

"Pardon?"

"What was your previous mission?"

"Guarding the Lesser Family Head, obviously."

"Really?"

I chuckled, pulled *that* from inside my robes, and tossed it onto the table.

Clatter.

Hyuk Mujin sucked in a breath at the sight of the golden mask gleaming on the table.

"Gasp! W-Where did you get that…?"

"Where do you think? I knew you weren't usually that kind of guy, but you stuck to me like a bad smell after the preliminaries."

"Wait. You've got it all wrong. I was genuinely so busy with guard duty that I barely had time to open my eyes—"

"A misunderstanding? Fine. Want me to make sure you never open them again?"

Crack!

The golden mask crumpled into a little ball in my hand. Hyuk Mujin's eyes shook as though caught in an earthquake.

“You were handling an escort at a gambling house, you bastard? You were so famous I didn’t even need to ask around. Apparently, some guy won a hundred thousand silver nyang[1465] in one go, then lost a hundred thousand silver nyang[1466] right afterward. They were treating him like a legend—no, an absolute legend.”

If the story had reached my ears even in the middle of this crisis, that said everything.

I’d even heard a rumor that one of the servants working at the Murim Alliance had hit the jackpot on Toto[1467]—no, Dodo—slapped the Chief Steward across the face, and walked out.

“If you cared about your subordinates that much, you should’ve collected dues and placed the bet with their money. Did you really gobble it down by yourself because you were afraid the payout odds would drop?”

“…”

No answer. Nothing to say.

Even if he had ten mouths, he wouldn’t have anything to say. Hyuk Mujin stood there frozen and pale before finally forcing out a few words.

“Life is… all about one big score.”

“…”

This bastard still hadn’t come to his senses.

I stared at Hyuk Mujin in disbelief and raised my fist.

That was when—

Swish. Tap.

There had been no noticeable presence. No sound.

As if by magic, a young man—or rather, an old man—had ascended more than ten jang[1468] and landed on the windowsill. He grinned and waved.

“Want to talk for a moment, friend?”

Friend, my ass.

I looked at Sword Saint Mae Jonghak and heaved an inward sigh.

[1465] A silver nyang is a traditional currency unit; it is not Korean won.

[1466] A silver nyang is a traditional currency unit; it is not Korean won.

[1467] Toto refers to sports betting in South Korea.

[1468] One jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is approximately 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

Chapter 269

It felt like sitting on a bed of thorns—or rather, walking down a path covered in them.

As I walked beside Mae Jonghak, the countless gazes coming my way made my face prickle.

They were filled with awe and curiosity.

Everyone knew now. The young martial artist who had been dismissed as a lucky country bumpkin just days ago was actually the great martial artist known as the Sword Saint.

“Is that really him? Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint.”

“Good heavens, he looks so young. I thought Returned to Youth was nothing more than an absurd fairy tale.”

“As expected of Great Hero Mae Jonghak. He’s turned the Murim upside down.”

Their hushed conversations slipped straight into my ears.

“But who’s that next to him?”

“That’s the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. I heard from someone yesterday that he grabbed Great Hero Mae Jonghak by the neck and talked to him like he was some punk, and—well, you know?”

“Good heavens. At that point, shouldn’t he be called the Mad Dragon instead of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?”

“…”

Fuck. It wasn’t like I’d done it knowingly. I hadn’t known who he was.

When I glared at the whispering crowd, Mae Jonghak burst out laughing.

“It’s all right. Friends can act that way with each other.”

He was killing me twice over.

We moved to a quiet rear garden away from the crowd.

It was still early spring, but the weather was warm and the flowers were in full bloom. Mae Jonghak gazed at blossoms whose names I didn’t know as we walked, then spoke.

“First, I should thank you.”

“For what…?”

“I heard you were a great help to Cheongpung.”

“I wouldn’t exactly call it help.”

“I don’t know the details, but if he went so far as to call you his Benefactor, you must have done a great deal for him.”

“…”

He didn’t know the details. He really, really didn’t.

I almost wanted to see the look on Mae Jonghak's face if he learned that a few candied hawthorn skewers[1469] were all it had taken for Cheongpung to start calling me his Benefactor.

"To be honest, I'd been very worried about that boy. But after meeting you, I was able to put my mind at ease. I owe you a debt."

"Oh. Right."

I decided not to mention the candied hawthorn skewers[1470]. If the Sword Saint said he owed me a debt, there was no reason to sell myself short.

"How is Cheongpung?"

"He's recovered enough to move around. The moment he opened his eyes, he threw a fit and insisted on coming to see you."

"Oh, dear. What happened?"

"Hmm? He quieted down when I gave him some dumplings."

Twenty years of child-rearing experience hadn't gone to waste. He knew exactly how to handle Cheongpung.

"And Great Hero Jeok?"

"He still hasn't regained consciousness. I actually wanted to ask you about that…"

"Ask me anything."

I struggled to force the words out.

"Is there a chance he might never wake up…?"

"Hmm."

Mae Jonghak stroked his smooth chin.

"What did the physician I sent say?"

"Ah, that man?"

Remembering the mouse-faced old physician who had briefly visited yesterday instantly soured my mood.

"He seemed like a complete quack."

"A quack? The Luoyang Strange Physician?"

"The Luoyang Strange Physician or whatever. He took one quick look, said there was nothing he could do right now, and walked straight out. How is that not quackery?"

What kind of old man had such a fierce temper? When I grabbed his arm in sheer disbelief, he screamed so loudly my ears nearly fell off.

Then he shouted that he would never examine Jeok Cheongang again, leaving me no choice but to let him go.

Mae Jonghak clicked his tongue after hearing the story.

[1469] Candied hawthorn skewers are fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

[1470] Candied hawthorn skewers are fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar.

“The Luoyang Strange Physician is renowned throughout the Central Plains. His temperament is every bit as eccentric as his epithet suggests, but his skill is beyond question.”

“Then…”

My heart sank at Mae Jonghak’s nod.

It must have shown plainly on my face, because he gave me a few reassuring pats on the back.

“Don’t worry too much. If Great Hero Jeok’s life had been in immediate danger, the Luoyang Strange Physician wouldn’t have simply left.”

His words were warm and comforting, but they didn’t completely dispel my unease.

Jeok Cheongang had seemed like he would shake it off and get back on his feet in no time.

For the past year, he had been my Master, passing everything he had on to me without reservation. At the same time, he was as good as my own grandfather.

No. He’ll be all right.

I forced down the anxiety rising inside me.

A martial artist counted among the ten greatest in the world and a renowned physician had already examined Jeok Cheongang. For now, all I could do was trust them.

Having settled on that, I changed the subject.

“Have you learned anything more about Dark Heaven?”

“Dark Heaven…”

Mae Jonghak gazed at the flower garden with an odd expression.

“I can’t make heads or tails of it.”

“Which parts?”

“All of it.”

“What?”

“Let me ask you something. Did anything about this incident strike you as strange?”

I thought for a while before answering.

So much had happened so urgently yesterday that I hadn’t noticed it at the time, but there were certainly several things that raised questions.

“There were a few things that seemed strange…”

“Such as?”

“For one thing, I don’t understand what those bastards were trying to accomplish.”

“Go on.”

“If Dark Heaven intended to deal a serious blow to the Murim, they should have prepared something much bigger.”

The leaders of the orthodox faction's Murim had all gathered in one place.

If Dark Heaven's goal was to destroy the orthodox faction and seize control of the world, they could at least have tried planting explosives.

Whether it succeeded or not, it was a golden opportunity to wipe out the enemy's leadership in one stroke.

Yet the only ones sacrificed were Dharma King Hong Dao and Shaolin Temple. Those bastards chose specific targets from the beginning and acted accordingly.

"Coming out into the open like this means they must have made at least some preparations for a fight… Yet it feels like they openly revealed themselves only to pick up iron coins instead of silver nyang."

Mae Jonghak, who had been listening in silence, suddenly spoke.

"That comparison is wrong. Shaolin Temple is a symbol of the orthodox faction. By destroying that symbol, Dark Heaven made sure the world knew they existed."

"Was that really necessary?"

"Several theories have emerged. The first is that they want a direct confrontation."

"Surely not."

"Don't underestimate demonic practitioners. They are people ruled solely by blood and power. The Demonic Cult during the Great Faction War was no different. They're impossible to read."

Mae Jonghak shook his head and continued.

"The second theory is that Dark Heaven is nothing more than a smokescreen."

"A smokescreen?"

"Do you know who caused the bloodbath at Shaolin Temple?"

"The Yin-Yang Twin Freaks… Ah."

"That's right. They were great fiends who earned fearsome reputations beneath the Demonic Cult's banner during the Great Faction War. Many years have passed, but there's still a strong possibility that they remain followers of the Demonic Cult."

So Dark Heaven might be a Demonic Cult franchise. No, a subordinate organization.

As Mae Jonghak said, it was entirely possible.

But there was still one thing bothering me.

"What about the Blood Lord? Is he part of the Demonic Cult too?"

"I don't know."

Mae Jonghak answered without the slightest hesitation, then scratched his chin.

"The Temporary Strength Pill you acquired, the Exploding Blood Demonic Art used by those who attacked Shaolin, and the Blood Lord himself. They all clearly carry the scent of the Demonic Cult, but… something is different. It has become darker and stranger."

Mae Jonghak was a living witness to the Great Faction War. He must have fought countless enemies and experienced their martial arts firsthand.

He was one of the orthodox Murim's foremost authorities on demonic martial arts. Anything he said might as well have been academic consensus.

"Especially that sorcery I witnessed at the end. Even I had never encountered anything like it."

It wasn't a movement technique or qinggong.[1471] It was sorcery.

I had heard that the Demonic Cult possessed all sorts of bizarre sorceries, but I had never imagined anything like that was possible.

Even I, someone accustomed to magic, had been left gaping in astonishment.

Wasn't that practically magic?

Martial artists had scoured the surrounding area in case he was still nearby, but the Blood Lord was nowhere to be found. He had truly vanished as though the earth had swallowed him.

"There has also been considerable debate over where so many enemies came from. If they can use that kind of sorcery on a large scale…"

"That's horrifying just to think about."

Calling it a surprise attack wouldn't even begin to cover it. If the enemy could pop up east and west like Hong Gil-dong,[1472] it would be like a bolt from the blue every time.

The leadership must be in chaos too.

The atmosphere had already been disorderly when I briefly attended the meeting the day before. By now, it could only have gotten worse.

I was clicking my tongue at the thought when Mae Jonghak asked,

"Have you ever wondered about something?"

Mae Jonghak's clear eyes fixed on me.

"Why were they so obsessed with the Green Jade Buddha Staff?"

"Who knows? Because it's Shaolin Temple's sacred treasure?"

"They could have simply broken it."

"I think they were more interested in taking it. Honestly, I'm not even sure what they planned to do with it."

As far as I knew, the Green Jade Buddha Staff was nothing more than a slightly unusual staff.

I thought it only seemed more impressive because it carried the authority of Shaolin's Abbot and the history of a thousand-year-old Shaolin Temple.

[1471] *Qinggong* is a martial-arts skill associated with swift, light-footed movement.

[1472] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw famed for appearing in different places with astonishing speed.

It wasn't the Elder Wand[1473] or anything. What were they going to do with a fluorescent green staff?

"Yes, that may be so. The others thought the same."

Mae Jonghak fell into thought for a while, then abruptly spoke again.

"Did you know that Master Hong Dao left me a letter?"

"This is the first I've heard of it since I grew pubic hair."

"Perhaps he sensed his own fate and made preparations. In the letter, he wrote that you were the Morning Star who would drive away the darkness."

"…"

"You're a genius unlike any I've ever seen. Look around you. Who else your age has reached such a realm?"

I thought for a moment before answering.

"Cheongpung."

"Oh. I see."

"…"

"Pung broke through the wall to the Peak realm when he was eighteen. I'd have thought you had done about the same by that age."

"I was doing well in a different sense back then. My epithet was the Night King."

"Oh, did it mean you were comparable to the Ten Kings?"

"No. I went in and out of pleasure houses too often."

"Oh. I see."

"…"

"…"

An icy silence descended.

Mae Jonghak scratched the back of his head, momentarily unable to find anything to say, then let out a hollow laugh.

"That's my grandson."

"…I think I'll be going now."

As I turned away, Mae Jonghak shouted after me.

"I'll drop by again soon! And I'll bring news that will surprise you!"

Ugh. Why did I feel so drained?

"Have you returned?"

When I returned to the room where Jeok Cheongang lay, Hyuk Mujin greeted me with a bow. Unlike before, he now stood rigidly at attention, and I smiled with satisfaction.

[1473] The Elder Wand is a powerful magical wand in the *Harry Potter* stories.

“That’s how you stand guard. You can draw your sword at any moment. Isn’t that nice?”

“Of course. I’ll guard this place like an iron fortress.”

“Yeah. You can go now.”

“Yes, sir!”

Hyuk Mujin was about to dart out of the room when I spoke.

“Put the lump of gold in your sleeve back down.”

“…”

“If it isn’t down by the time I count to three, you’re getting murdered today. One, two.”

Clatter.

Hyuk Mujin put down the gold mask I had crushed into a lump earlier and lowered his head dejectedly.

“Ah. You knew?”

“Do I look like an easy mark?”

“Captain, please. I even took on Yama’s Debt[1474] this time…”

A hundred thousand silver nyang hadn’t been enough, so he had even borrowed from a loan shark. What a lunatic.

I clicked my tongue and tucked the lump of gold into my robes.

“We’ll see. It depends on how you behave.”

“Gasp. Does that mean…?”

“I’m going to rest now, so don’t let anyone in. Not even my eldest brother.”

“E-Even the Lesser Family Head?”

“That’s right. Tell them I’m exhausted and asleep.”

I looked out the window. The sky was slowly turning red.

“Until tomorrow morning. Can you manage that?”

Hyuk Mujin nodded resolutely.

“I’ll give my life.”

“I already know you won’t, so just do what I told you.”

“Yes, sir!”

Some “yes, sir.”

Hyuk Mujin’s face lit up, and he moved aside with a broad grin.

I gazed at Jeok Cheongang’s face, which looked as though he were sleeping soundly, then lay down on the bed beside him.

How long had it been?

[1474] Yama is a judge of the dead in Buddhist tradition. “Yama’s Debt” is Taekyung’s joking name for a ruinous loan.

I had spent the past year running without a moment’s rest. Now, I desperately wanted to loosen the reins a little and return to my family’s embrace.

Logout.

Ding.

With the familiar notification sound, my vision went black.

Chapter 270

Ding.

My eyes flew open with the familiar System notification.

Instead of the familiar ceiling, I found two pairs of eyes staring down at me.

The moment our gazes met—

“Eek!”

“Oh my God!”

They both let out piercing shrieks and fell backward onto their butts.

I yawned as though I had just woken up and looked at Mom and Hayeon.

“What are you so surprised about?”

“Gasp… Haaah…”

“Huuh… Huuuuu…”

They looked as though they had seen a ghost. Still sitting on the floor and catching their breath, they shouted at the same time.

“You nearly gave me a heart attack!”

“You little bastard! You little bastard!”

Smack! Smack!

Hayeon’s eyes blazed, while Mom charged in and mercilessly pounded my back.

Somehow, the palm of a woman in her fifties hurt worse than the fist of an average martial artist.

Was this some kind of Inner-Family Heavy Hand?

The Mother’s Palm Strike, remembered by both body and soul.

It was only after I had taken many more blows that the barrage of slaps finally stopped.

Of course, getting hit a few times didn’t solve all my problems.

“Son.”

I swallowed hard at the weight in Mom’s voice. As expected, the mood was ominous.

“Yes, yes, Mother.”

“Do you know you’ve been sleeping for two whole days?”

Hayeon added, “Forty-two hours, to be exact.”

“That’s right. You wouldn’t wake up, so we almost called an ambulance.”

Forty-two hours.

I'd slept quite a while. I had spent more than a year in Murim, after all, so it made sense that this much time had passed.

To be honest, I hadn't expected it to take this long either.

"Do you have narcolepsy or something? How can you sleep that long? You didn't even react when we shook you."

Hayeon stared at me in disbelief, and I casually began piling lie upon lie.

"What are you talking about? I woke up once or twice in the middle."

"You didn't. Every time Mom and I checked, you were sleeping…"

"I woke up around dawn each day. How could you have seen me?"

"Huh?"

"Every time I opened my eyes, it was around dawn. I was tired, so I just kept sleeping."

"No, but even so, can a person really do that?"

Of course not.

But I had long since mastered the art of dealing with this distrustful little menace of a sister.

"Hey, Jin Hayeon."

I deliberately hardened my expression as I called her by her full name, and Hayeon flinched.

"Y-Yeah?"

"Don't you know what I was like in high school?"

"I-I don't."

"I slept straight through all seven periods without even eating, then slept again during evening self-study."

"…"

"You think that's all?"

"There's more?"

"Of course. After sleeping at school, what do you think I did at home?"

"Could it be…"

"That's right. I came home from school and went back to sleep. That's the kind of person I am."

"That's incredible."

Hayeon nodded solemnly. Mom, who had been listening quietly, looked utterly crushed as she spoke.

"Son, that's not something to brag about…"

Sorry, Mom.

But something similar might happen again, so it seemed better to hammer the point home now.

The problem was that I was hammering another huge nail into my mother's heart.

There goes another point on my unfilial-son score.

I quietly avoided Mom's gaze. It wasn't as though my poor academic performance was anything new. Thankfully, the whole narcolepsy business disappeared from the conversation.

Before Hayeon could say anything else, I changed the subject.

"Oh, right. The massage chair. Weren't we going to buy one?"

Hayeon answered with a look of utter contempt.

"We already bought one, you idiot."

"Oh, really?"

"Yeah. I picked the most expensive one. It was worth every penny. I reclined in it for a minute and nearly went straight to heaven."

"You're taking the express train to hell when you die. Where did you get the money?"

"What do you mean, where? It was all your money. Here. I put your card to good use."

"…Right. Good job."

When had she taken my card?

But I had my own crimes to answer for, so I couldn't say anything.

How much did the most expensive one cost, anyway? Maybe I should have kept more of the money from selling the raid monster last time.

I was mulling it over as I took back the card when—

Ding-dong.

Mom and Hayeon's ears perked up at the doorbell.

"Could that be them?"

"They're here!"

What was here?

I asked with a bewildered expression.

"Is someone coming?"

"Of course. The delivery driver."

Hayeon answered excitedly and dashed out of the room.

But a moment later, the voice that accompanied the sound of the front door opening did not belong to the delivery driver Hayeon had been waiting for.

"Excuse me. Is Jin Taekyung here?"

"Who…? Are you perhaps a reporter?"

"No."

A soft yet low voice continued.

"I'm a Team Leader. The Peace Guild's Team Leader."

There was only one Peace Guild Team Leader I knew.

When I stepped into the living room, I saw a man in a black coat over Hayeon's shoulder.

"Team Leader."

Team Leader Choi dipped his head in greeting.

"Have you been resting well?"

"…More or less."

In truth, spending over a year struggling in Murim had left me mentally exhausted.

It had been a while since I'd seen him, but I felt more uneasy than glad. If this man had come all the way to my house, his business was obvious.

"I'm glad to hear you've had a good rest."

"I didn't say I'd had a good rest. No, wait—what brings you here? I thought I didn't have any media appearances scheduled for a while."

"That's only natural. You aren't a celebrity, after all."

"Then?"

"The workshop for our new Guild members is today."

"A workshop?"

"Yes."

That was fine. I was curious what the new Guild members were like, and I could go for a little while before coming home and getting some proper rest.

"When does the workshop end?"

"It's scheduled to last about six nights and seven days."

"What kind of workshop lasts a whole week? Are we going to Pyeongchang or Gapyeong?"

"Think bigger."

"Then maybe… an overseas resort in Southeast Asia?"

"Hmm."

"Phuket? It's Phuket, isn't it!"

Team Leader Choi beamed at me.

"We've secured an A-rank Gate."

"Oh."

"We'll build team unity while hunting monsters together."

"…"

A workshop with monsters.

Wonderful.

Rumble. Boom!

The ground shook every time the five-meter-tall[1475] giant took a step.

Its entire body, from head to toe, was made of solid rock. Moss clung to it here and there, and the whole thing looked damp with moisture.

A red light flashed from the uppermost rock, where vines hung down like hair.

The monster's eye.

Someone groaned under their breath as that lifeless eye swept over them.

"Golem…"

A bona fide A-rank monster.

The rookie B-rank Hunters who had just graduated from the training center felt their knees weaken at the mere sight of it.

"How are we supposed to take that down…?"

"I feel like one hit would kill me."

Just as the roughly twenty new Guild members were watching the Stone Golem loitering in the distance and swallowing dryly, someone spoke.

"There's no need to be afraid. The Stone Golem approaching us possesses tremendous destructive power and durability, but it does have one weakness: it's slow."

At the young Team Leader's words—he looked as though he had just stepped out of a fashion magazine—the female Hunters nodded with dreamy expressions.

"They say it's slow."

"If Team Leader Choi Minwoo says it's slow, then it's slow. He's right."

At that moment, the Stone Golem's head slowly turned toward them.

A brief silence followed.

Then its rocky legs accelerated, devouring three meters[1476] with every stride.

Boom, boom, boom, boom!

"…It's really fast, though."

"Fuck, I should've gone with damage dealer instead of tank."

"Excuse me. Do you think damage dealers are people who sit around and eat for free?"

"Then take my shield and tank it for me."

"I'd rather not."

The dark clouds hanging over the new Guild members' faces scattered when a clear voice rang out.

"The wind dwells within you. Haste!"

"Power that can shatter stone. Strength!"

[1475] Five meters is about 16 ft.

[1476] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

“Breathe life into your weary bodies. Healing!”

Fwoooosh.

The incantations rang out one after another.

A refreshing breeze swept over them, and halos of light descended onto the new Guild members’ heads.

Feeling their bodies grow vastly stronger than before, they turned around in astonishment.

What is this? The difference is incredible.

She’s a B-rank healer like me, but her effect is this strong?

Wow. So she really is from the Ares Guild.

Under their collective stare, Song Song’s flawless brow furrowed.

“What are you all doing? Do you want to keep standing there glassy-eyed until you have your workshop in heaven?”

They had been left dazed once by her buff magic—powerful enough to make them mistake her for an A-rank healer—and a second time by her beauty.

Only then did the new Guild members snap out of it.

Boom, boom, boom, boom!

—Grrrroooar!

The Stone Golem had already closed to within twenty meters.[1477] It swung its arm.

Whoooosh!

With an air-splitting roar, a massive tree that had stood rooted deep in the ground moments before shot toward them like a cannonball.

“S-Shields!”

Clack-clack-clack!

At the panicked cry, several tower shields filled with mana rose to block the front.

But could those shields really stop a massive tree fired at them like a bullet?

Everyone gritted their teeth, bracing for the impact.

“Fire Wall.”

Fwoooosh!

A massive wall of flame surged upward.

The intense heat incinerated the dry branches and leaves. The blackened trunk crumbled the instant it struck the tower shields.

“Whoa…”

“What is this?”

A rich baritone worthy of a coffee commercial drifted down from above the new Guild members’ gaping faces.

“I blocked that one for you. There won’t be a second time.”

[1477] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

It was strange. His words and actions were impeccably polite, yet the old gentleman's eyes held the same viciousness as the training Instructor who had tormented them until recently.

No, it was even worse.

"Fire Wall."

With the second incantation, another wall of flame surged upward.

The only difference was that this time, it appeared behind them instead of in front.

"Ah, hot!"

"What the hell is this?"

"Guild Master! Guild Master?"

Kim the Butler blocked off the new Guild members' rear with a curtain of fire and smiled faintly.

"You cannot grow by receiving nothing but help inside a Gate. Fight as though your lives depend on it."

"…"

"Mages, locate the core with detection magic. Tanks, protect the healers and draw its aggro. Damage dealers… I trust I don't need to explain any further."

Swoosh.

Kim the Butler flicked his fingers, and Team Leader Choi and Song Song's bodies rose into the air.

The abandoned new Guild members were just about to fall into a panic when a shout rang out.

"Tanks, forward!"

Boom!

With a thunderous cry, a massive man in full armor slammed a tower shield into the ground.

Several of the new Guild members frowned at the sight.

The first man to step forward was a middle-aged D-rank Hunter whose only claim to distinction was twenty years of experience.

"What are you doing? Get your heads in the game!"

But they had no choice. Their bodies, already sensing the threat to their lives, moved toward the front line of their own accord.

"Formation!"

"Formaaation!"

Clack-clack-clack!

With a deafening chorus repeating the command, the tower shields formed a solid wall.

The mages and healers drew up their mana, while the damage dealers prepared the strongest strikes they could unleash.

Crouched behind the shields, Im Kkeokjeong shouted with a grim expression.

“Hold!”

—Grrrroooar!

The Stone Golem charged straight into the wall of shields.

Kra-boom!

“Gasp… Haaah…”

“Ugh…”

Heavy breathing and groans rose from every direction.

The tank with a broken arm and the mages and healers who had exhausted all their mana collapsed onto the ground, while the damage dealers lay sprawled across the Stone Golem’s remains.

“Ugh, I’m dying.”

“Did we really take down this Stone Golem?”

The raid had lasted a full five hours. Despite their numbers, it had been a long, grueling fight, but the rookie Hunters who had only just graduated from the training center felt their chests swell with pride.

“I took down an A-rank monster…”

“Let’s take a group picture later. I’m going to frame it and hang it in my living room.”

“Who takes down a Stone Golem for their first raid?”

“Good work, everyone.”

Just as everyone was looking back on their achievement with moved expressions

—

—Grrrrooooar!

—Roooooar!

The new Guild members’ faces went rigid as they spotted more golems approaching in the distance with thunderous roars.

What is that?

There were more than ten at a glance, and they looked larger and tougher than the Stone Golem. Light flashed from their massive bodies with every violent movement.

Someone shrieked.

“Iron! Those are Iron Golems!”

“Eeeek!”

The appearance of Iron Golems, among the highest-ranking of all golems, was more than enough to send everyone into a panic.

“W-Why are they here?”

“Aren’t they supposed to be scattered all over the place?”

They had never heard of golems living in tribes.

But the sight of them drawing closer by the second, and the ground trembling as though an earthquake had struck, told them this was all too real.

In the end, they had only one lifeline left.

“Please help us! We’ll all die at this rate!”

The cry rose toward the sky. Team Leader Choi, who had been floating in the air and watching the situation from beginning to end, smiled.

“There’s nothing for us to help you with.”

“…What did you say?”

Has that bastard gone insane?

Just as everyone began to doubt their own ears—

Whoooosh! Slash!

A red flash tore through the air.

The charging Iron Golem split cleanly in half, from the crown of its head to its crotch.

Crash!

A man emerged between the masses of steel collapsing to either side.

“Mob farming is fucking sweet.”

The young man, Jin Taekyung, grinned.

Chapter 271

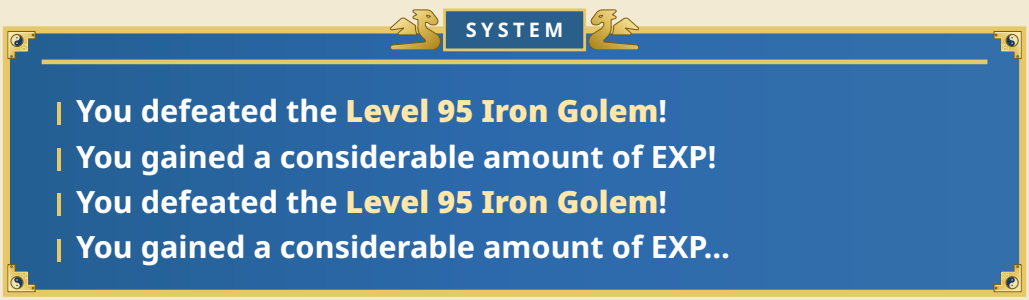
Shhk!

The Iron Golem's impossibly sturdy body was sliced apart like soft tofu.

Even steel imbued with mana couldn't withstand Scorching Yang Qi.

Everywhere the spearhead cut and pierced, it carved a trail of fire, leaving molten metal dripping to the ground.

Ding. Ding.



"Why is it so weak?"

Even I was bewildered by what I'd just done.

Iron Golems were difficult monsters. No, extremely difficult. They couldn't be killed without destroying their cores, and their destructive power and durability were both tremendous.

Regeneration that surpasses a Troll's and destructive power that rivals an ogre's.

On top of that, they had inexhaustible stamina and resistance to magic.

Their only flaw was that they were somewhat slow, but considering their countless advantages, could that really even be called a flaw?

There was a reason they were considered some of the strongest A-rank Golems. And yet...

Why is this so easy?

Whoooosh!

The pressure from the wind sent my hair flying. An Iron Golem's fist came crashing down toward the crown of my head.

A scream erupted from among the rookie Guild members.

"Look out!"

That rookie needed some training. If a teammate looked like they were in danger, they should have picked up a rock lying nearby and at least tried to distract the enemy. What were they doing?

Well, he is a rookie.

I clicked my tongue and clenched my fist.

In the brief instant that remained after splitting a second in half, then splitting it again, decades of internal energy raced down my arm.

Scorching Yang Qi transformed into blue flames and gathered around my fist.

And then…

Claaang!

I drove my fist forward.

Fist against fist. Iron Fist against the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

The ground caved in with a metallic clang, and compressed air exploded outward. Through the swirling wind, I saw the Iron Golem stagger backward.

Only seconds ago, its arm had been solid and gleaming. Now it melted and dripped away as if a fire dragon had swallowed it.

—Grill?

Iron Golems were magical puppets without emotions.

Yet at that moment, I could have sworn I sensed bewilderment from the creature.

“Yeah. Of course I’m grilling you.”

I kicked off the ground and shot upward.

The Iron Golem’s gleaming steel chest filled my vision. And then I sensed it.

Deep within its enormous body, which contained not a trace of qi, something pulsed and poured out mana.

The Golem’s core.

“This Hunter offers free grilling.”

I slammed my open palm into its chest. The cool metal was consumed by the heat of the Flame Divine Palm.

Hisssss!

Molten metal sprayed outward as a huge hole opened in the Golem’s chest. The core that had supplied it with mana shattered without resistance.

—Grrrrr…

Rumble!

Deprived of its core, the enormous body lost all strength, broke into pieces, and collapsed.

Just as a person couldn’t breathe with a ruptured heart, neither could an Iron Golem.

I landed lightly atop the heap of metal piled up like a small hill.

“All right. Next.”

—Griiiill!

With mechanical roars, waves of gleaming steel surged toward me from every direction.

If I kill all of these, I should level up at least once, right?

Anticipation rising, I swung my spear.

The Fire Dragon Divine Spear, now at the seventh stage, burned through air and sound alike, carving a path of fire.

Fwoooosh!

Rumble!

The final Iron Golem collapsed with a deafening crash.

It had taken only a few minutes to dispose of more than ten A-rank monsters.

When I looked around, everyone was staring at me in shock.

“This is insane…”

“Did you see that? Did you just see that?”

“Yes. I saw it.”

“Wow, he was playing with an A-rank monster. I couldn’t even see him move.”

“I told you I saw it.”

A voice rang out above the murmuring rookie Guild members.

“Is the raid over already? After combat, clean up the remains and keep watch over the surrounding area. Guild Master and Miss Song, please take charge.”

His words were polite, but his tone cracked like a whip.

Team Leader Choi landed lightly, and the rookies flinched before hurrying off to find something to do.

He really does have charisma sometimes.

Maybe it was that unique aura of his. You had to be born with something like that.

As I was thinking this, Team Leader Choi approached and spoke with a grave expression.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung. I’ve been thinking about this for a while, but I can’t hold back any longer.”

“Yes.”

“Where did you buy that spear?”

“…”

Right. This was the kind of person he was. I’d forgotten for a moment.

Whether he knew what I was thinking or not, Team Leader Choi’s gaze remained fixed on the spear in my hand—White Flame.

“It’s like looking at a work of art. A classical yet beautiful Chinese-style design. Don’t tell me it’s made from Magic Gem?”

No. It’s made from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

Of course, telling him the truth would only cause trouble, so I gave him a vague answer.

"I'm not sure. I don't know much about it myself."

Team Leader Choi's covetous gaze traveled up and down the spear.

"If you don't mind my asking, would you consider selling it to me…?"

"No. It's not for sale."

Even if I wanted to sell it, I couldn't. It was a bound Item that only I could use. The Item information said so, too.

Perhaps for that reason, it was the only object in my two separate inventories—the ones divided between Murim and the modern world—that could travel between the two worlds.

"Ah…"

Team Leader Choi smacked his lips in disappointment, then changed the subject.

"Regardless, I'm truly impressed. You just keep getting stronger."

I answered half-jokingly and half-seriously.

"All it takes is training like hell for a year under a Supreme Peak master with dementia."

"Dementia? What did you say?"

"A Supreme Peak master."

"Isn't that a term from wuxia[1478] novels? Peak master, Supreme Peak master."

"That's right. I'm thinking of writing a novel as a hobby after I retire. Something like *Login Murim*."

"That title isn't very good. It won't be a hit."

"I'm not actually planning to write it."

Team Leader Choi let out a short laugh before speaking.

"I know I've said this before, but sometimes, when I look at you, Mr. Jin Taekyung, a certain thought crosses my mind."

"What thought?"

"Whether you and I are truly the same kind of person."

His light brown eyes seemed to grow hot and reddish.

"A perennial F-rank Hunter becoming this powerful in only a few months? If I hadn't seen you with my own eyes, I never would have believed it."

It was a reasonable suspicion.

Second-awakened Hunters were uncommon, but not so few that they could be considered exceedingly rare.

In my case, however, I had reached a realm far beyond any ordinary second awakening.

What's more, Team Leader Choi had watched my transformation from closer than anyone else.

[1478] *Wuxia* is a genre of Chinese fiction about martial artists and their adventures.

I might fool everyone else, but not Team Leader Choi.

To him, I was no different from a second-, third-, or fourth-awakened Hunter.

I licked my dry lips.

This was a secret I had to take to my grave.

If it ever got out, I might be dragged off by the NIS[1479]—or no, NASA—and spend the rest of my life as a test subject.

"Team Leader. I'm sorry, but that's…"

Team Leader Choi shook his head slightly and cut me off.

"I know. I understand that you have secrets you can't even tell me. In a way, I'm in a similar position, so I have no intention of pressing you."

A similar position?

Before the question could fully form in my mind, he continued.

"An unprecedented second-awakened Hunter unlike anything the world has ever seen. That explanation should be enough, shouldn't it? Butler Kim feels the same way I do."

Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong had joined us later, but Butler Kim had been at Team Leader Choi's side, watching me grow.

News articles were already pouring out under headlines like *The F-Rank Hunter's Rebellion* and *A Miracle*. If the two of them kept their mouths shut, I could probably bring things to an end here.

I dipped my head.

"Thank you. I owe you one."

"Don't mention it."

"But may I ask you one thing?"

"Anything."

"Why are you going this far for me?"

"Oh, that?"

Team Leader Choi gave a breathy laugh.

"You just said it yourself. You owe me."

"I did."

"And I intend to collect that debt in full—with interest."

"…?"

"That's all you need to know. Well, then."

Team Leader Choi turned to leave, then paused.

"That novel you mentioned earlier—if you ever write it, let me read it. I enjoy novels more than you might think."

"Then you won't be able to read mine."

[1479] The NIS is South Korea's National Intelligence Service.

"Why not?"

Because if I ever write it, it won't be a novel you'd enjoy. It'll be an essay about my own experiences.

Team Leader Choi tilted his head at my silent smile.

The workshop—or rather, the raid—scheduled to last six nights and seven days ended after only three.

I had wandered around alone and beaten down every monster I saw, leaving nothing else to hunt.

"It was supposed to be a raid for team bonding, but somehow it turned out like this."

I quietly avoided Song Song's incredulous stare.

Wiping out all the Golems inside the Gate hadn't been enough. I'd even soloed the boss monster.

That EXP was so sweet.

"Ahem."

"The rookies need raid experience, too. Why are you so desperate to jump in every time you see a monster?"

"Come on, it all worked out. Let it go."

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Now, now. Let's just let it go, Miss Song."

"And if I just can't let it go?"

"I'll punish you by confessing my feelings."

"…"

Song Song pressed her lips shut and slowly backed away with a frightened expression.

I got what I wanted, so why do I feel like crying?

Hah. I loved you…

I trudged away like the tragic male lead of a romance.

The moment I exited the dungeon, the reporters camped outside the Gate set off a barrage of camera flashes.

I had spent an entire year in Murim, but only a few days had passed in the modern world.

It would take more time for all the interest and excitement surrounding me to die down.

"Please step back, reporters!"

"Only authorized personnel are allowed beyond this point!"

Only after the guards rushed in and held back the press did I escape the barrage of flashes.

Once the shutter sounds finally stopped, the rookie Guild members, their faces flushed with excitement, shouted loudly.

“Thank you for your hard work!”

Their eyes sparkled. Their gazes were filled with admiration and respect as they looked at us.

Though, of course, most of that attention was focused on me.

Feeling awkward, I turned toward the founding members. That was when I realized someone was missing.

“Where’s Uncle Kkeokjeong?”

“Huh? Now that you mention it, he isn’t here.”

Team Leader Choi answered.

“He told me privately on the way here, then slipped away. Apparently something came up.”

“What could be so urgent that he left without even changing out of his gear?”

“It must be urgent if he left like that.”

What was going on? Had something happened at home?

An uneasy feeling settled in the back of my mind.

Come to think of it, I didn’t get to talk with him much after returning.

I had spent most of the raid operating alone, so I hadn’t had many chances to talk with the others.

Looking back, Im Kkeokjeong’s expression had seemed a little dark. At the time, I’d assumed he was simply nervous, but…

Did something really serious happen?

Even after I changed out of my gear and everyone went their separate ways, I couldn’t stop thinking about it.

I debated for a long time whether to call him, but in the end, I sent a quick message to the number saved in my contacts. It simply said that we should grab a drink together soon.

He probably had his own problems to deal with, and sticking my nose in where it didn’t belong might be rude.

That should be enough.

I was staring at the stubborn number 1[1480] that refused to disappear when—

Bzzzzt.

My smartphone vibrated. A phone icon appeared on the screen, along with the saved name.

[1480] In Korean messaging apps, a number beside a sent message indicates how many recipients have not read it.

It was a name I had saved several months ago and completely forgotten about.

Garam Middle School Classmate Park Jihoon

I had run into him by chance on the day I went to buy a house, and he hadn’t contacted me once since.

What could he want?

Mildly curious, I answered the call.

Chapter 272

“Hello?”

The voice on the other end of the phone sounded unfamiliar.

The Park Jihoon I remembered from middle school hadn’t even finished going through his voice change, and since then, we’d only exchanged a few words in passing when we ran into each other a few months ago.

Is this really him?

I was still hesitating when he spoke again.

“Is this Jin Taekyung’s number?”

“Oh, yeah, it’s me. I thought you might be someone else.”

“What the hell? You didn’t save my number last time?”

“I did, but for a second I thought you might’ve called the wrong number. I didn’t recognize your voice.”

“Fair enough. That was the first time we’d seen each other since middle school.”

“True. I didn’t even recognize you then.”

“Of course you didn’t. Do you have any idea how much money I poured into this face?”

A low laugh came through the phone. There wasn’t a trace of awkwardness between us; the mood felt warm and familiar.

I laughed along as I climbed into the VIP limousine provided by the Gate Management Agency. The driver met my eyes in the rearview mirror and gave me a polite nod before smoothly pulling away.

“So, what’s up?”

“Nothing much. I called to see if you wanted to grab a drink.”

“Drinks? Out of the blue?”

“Yeah. I said I’d get in touch when we had our class reunion, but I never did.”

Did he?

Thinking back, it seemed like he had. I’d been so busy since then that I’d completely forgotten.

“Something came up at the last minute, and I had to go overseas on business. I couldn’t even make it to the reunion.”

“An overseas business trip?”

“There was a problem at our European branch. I only got back recently.”

I went to Murim, and this guy went to Europe.

I had no idea what he’d done there, but for some reason, I felt cheated. I spoke with as much envy as I could muster.

“You lucky bastard. Must’ve been nice getting to see Europe.”

"You're jealous of me? You?"

Park Jihoon burst out laughing on the other end of the line.

"That feels really weird coming from you. Are you trying to rub it in?"

"No, that's not what I meant."

"I'm kidding. So, are you free tonight?"

I glanced at the time. It was already eight in the evening.

I'd moved out of our family home and into an officetel[1481] in Bucheon three days ago, so even if I went home, the only person waiting for me would be Jinho hyung.[1482]

I had time. The problem was…

He doesn't have some other motive, does he?

But I only hesitated for a moment.

I'd been a Hunter for seven years. Even the close friends I'd been inseparable from during my school days had gradually stopped contacting me long ago.

Out of sight, out of mind didn't apply only to romantic relationships.

And yet here I was, suspecting a friend who had contacted me after all this time without any ulterior motive.

Have I developed trust issues or something?

The aftermath of the Won Myunghoon incident, along with the harassment I'd endured from certain trash reporters, must have left a lasting mark. I was left with a bitter taste in my mouth.

"You must be pretty busy. I guess that makes sense. Then maybe next time…"

"No, I'm free now. Where should we meet?"

A little while later, the limousine gliding down the road changed course.

"You got here faster than I expected."

Park Jihoon was already outside waiting for me.

The weather was gradually turning toward winter. In his cashmere coat over a crisp white shirt, he looked completely different from me.

"What's with the outfit? Why are you so dressed up?"

"I have something important to take care of today. And let's get one thing straight. It's not that I'm dressed up—you're dressed down."

"Hey, what's wrong with what I'm wearing? Jeans and a sweatshirt are perfectly fine."

[1481] An officetel is a Korean mixed-use unit designed to function as both an office and a residence.

[1482] *Hyung* is a familiar term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

This was me making an effort, too. Hayeon had kept squawking at me to stop wearing tracksuits when so many people were watching.

“Where did all the money you earned go…? Oh, right. You donated it.”

“Don’t bring that up. It still hurts.”

“That’s why I called you. When something’s eating at you, alcohol is the best medicine.”

Park Jihoon grinned and jerked his chin toward the entrance, then started walking.

We passed a uniformed security guard and countless surveillance cameras installed throughout the grounds before finally making it inside.

The sight that greeted me left my mouth hanging open.

What the hell is this?

The marble floor glittered beneath the lights, while paintings that looked as though they had come straight out of the seventeenth century hung in frames along the walls.

I think I saw that one in an art textbook. There’s no way it’s genuine, right? Yeah. It can’t be.

I followed him, gawking like a country bumpkin.

We stopped in front of five elevators lined up side by side.

There weren’t even any buttons, so I had no idea what I was supposed to do. Then Jihoon placed his hand on a black panel, and an elevator descended in the blink of an eye with a mechanical whine.

Bzzzzing.

“What are you doing? Get in.”

“…Wow.”

“What are you so surprised about?”

“Nothing. I just thought you said this was an officetel.”[1483]

“It is. An officetel.”[1484]

“…”

The officetel[1485] he knew and the one I knew seemed to be two entirely different things. I swallowed the words before they could slip out.

Maybe it was because we were in Cheongdam-dong, but the place practically reeked of wealth from the entrance onward.

“You really made it. You even bought a place like this.”

“It came onto the market recently, so I bought it. I thought I could stop by now and then to clear my head.”

[1483] An officetel is a Korean mixed-use unit designed to function as both an office and a residence.
[1484] An officetel is a Korean mixed-use unit designed to function as both an office and a residence.
[1485] An officetel is a Korean mixed-use unit designed to function as both an office and a residence.

Anyone listening to him would think he'd bought a pair of shoes.

As I shook my head in disbelief, the elevator stopped and the doors opened. Instead of a cold, dark hallway, a living room decorated in shades of gray spread out before me.

I didn't know the exact square footage, but the living room alone was about the same size as our family home.

"Come in."

I had no idea whether he'd really bought the place just to clear his head, but one thing was certain: I'd never been anywhere like it.

The enormous lounge suite and wine cellar in the living room made it look as though someone had picked up an upscale bar and moved it inside.

Park Jihoon took off his coat and asked, "What do you want to drink?"

"What do you have?"

"Château Cheval Blanc, Screaming Eagle Cabernet Sauvignon, Royal de Maria…"

What the hell is he talking about?

I blinked at the stream of alien words.

"Chateau Shibal, what?"[1486]

"Château Cheval Blanc."

Whether it was château or shatto, every single name was impossibly complicated.

After a brief silence, I asked, "Don't you have any somaek?"[1487]

Park Jihoon let out a short laugh.

We stacked up a crate each of soju and beer and drank without pause.

It had been eleven years since we'd lost touch in our third year of middle school, so we had a mountain of things to talk about.

"Remember that guy No Jaehun from the class next door?"

"Who was No Jaehun?"

"The tall guy who used to brag about working out. Anyway, when he got into a fight with Seon Woongje from our class, you—"

"Wait. Who the hell is Seon Woongje?"

"…Do you have amnesia or something?"

We talked about everything from trivial memories of middle school to what we'd been doing since we lost touch.

The only time either of us stopped talking was to drink.

[1486] *Shibal* is a Korean profanity; here, Taekyung mishears the similar-sounding "Cheval."

[1487] *Somaek* is a drink made by mixing soju, a Korean distilled spirit, with beer.

At some point, I realized the corners of my mouth had been turned up for quite a while.

This is fun.

How could I put it? Drinking with someone you felt comfortable around was always enjoyable, but there was something a little more special about sharing a drink with a friend who shared the same memories.

The atmosphere was so warm and friendly that I felt like an idiot for having suspected him, even briefly, during our phone call.

I also learned a few things about him that I'd never known before.

"You were born with a silver spoon?"

"Silver spoon is a bit much. My father just runs a small business."

"A Hunter-related business that he's been running for more than thirty years?"

"Yeah."

"That makes you a silver-spoon kid, you deceitful bastard. Guys who talk like you always turn out to be the ones who are genuinely rich."

I looked at him.

It wasn't that he suddenly looked different now that I knew he was rich. I just found it fascinating.

The neighborhood where we'd lived back then had been perfectly ordinary. If it hadn't been, someone like me—whose school grades had been determined by rolling a mechanical pencil to guess the answers—would never have gotten in.

The Hunter industry, on the other hand, was practically a gold mine.

If his family had survived for thirty years amid such fierce competition, it wouldn't have been strange to find gold bars rolling around their house.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"It's just weird. Don't rich kids usually go to Gangnam's famous School District 8 or somewhere like that?"[1488]

"I guess I'm not a rich kid, then. Besides, I transferred in, remember?"

"You transferred? That's the first I've heard of it."

"Yeah. In our second year of middle school. There wasn't any reason to mention it."

"Wasn't there?"

"No."

I tilted my head and took another drink.

Then again, what did it matter that he'd transferred schools in middle school? It had happened more than ten years ago.

[1488] Gangnam's School District 8 refers to one of Seoul's most prestigious education districts, associated with affluent families and elite schools.

“We didn’t meet until our third year, anyway. We’d never crossed paths before then, so it makes sense that I wouldn’t know.”

“But we crossed paths plenty of times.”

“Huh?”

“A week after I transferred, I saw you for the first time in front of the teachers’ office. Then we ran into each other in the hallway. We crossed paths in the bathroom, too.”

Memories from more than ten years ago, already blurred into an indistinct mosaic, flowed from Park Jihoon’s lips.

“Wow… How do you remember all that?”

His perfectly smooth lips curved into a smile.

“I have a better memory than you’d think. Unlike some people.”

I topped off his empty glass and chuckled.

“Hey, my memory might be terrible, but there’s one thing I remember.”

“What?”

“You never did your homework. Every time we had a test, you guessed all the answers, put your head down, and went to sleep.”

“Oh, that.”

“If your memory was so good, why were your grades in memorization-heavy subjects so awful? Did you even go to college—ah, is that rude to ask?”

“What’s rude about it? I don’t care.”

“Then that’s a relief.”

“And I did go to college. Business Administration at Hankuk University. I awakened out of nowhere, so I still haven’t graduated.”

“Wait, where? Hankuk University?”

“My parents wanted me to go.”

“…You crazy bastard. Are there parents who don’t want their kid to get into Hankuk University?”

Hankuk University was the most prestigious university in the country. Only the brightest students from across Korea could get in.

Park Jihoon laughed lightly at my incredulous stare.

“When I actually tried, I got in. It wasn’t as hard as I expected.”

“Huh.”

How could I put it? The more I heard about his life, the more it sounded like a wide-open highway.

A wealthy family, a sharp mind, admission to the university everyone dreamed of, and then becoming an A-rank Awakened in one shot.

Unlike me, who’d been forced to provide for my family, becoming a Hunter had been just one of countless options available to him.

“Why?”

“Huh?”

“You were looking at me strangely.”

“Was it that obvious?”

“Very. Taekyung, are you perhaps…”

Park Jihoon propped his chin on one hand.

His alcohol-soaked voice continued in a low murmur.

“Are you jealous of me?”

Jealous?

The question was so unexpected that I stared blankly for a moment. Then I burst out laughing.

“Yeah. I guess that’s what it is.”

“…You’re honest.”

“It’s true. Longing for something I never had? Envy, maybe. Something like that. I don’t regret anything, though. I worked hard enough.”

Park Jihoon stared at me, his eyes widening slightly as though he hadn’t expected that answer.

“So you get jealous of people, too.”

“Hey, what am I, some kind of big shot?”

“You are. Look at yourself now. You’re a Hunter drawing attention from the foreign media as well as the domestic press. Before long, you might even become one of Korea’s five S-rank Hunters.”

“That sounds impressive—except I’m also the guy who made a donation and still trembles every time he thinks about the money.”

I let out a short laugh and emptied my glass. Park Jihoon gazed at me in silence, his lips parting as though he were about to say something.

That was when—

Bzzzt.

The smartphone on the table began to vibrate. Park Jihoon stared intently at the screen and licked his lips.

“Who is it?”

“My Guild Team Leader.”

“At this hour? Does the Myeongdong Guild have some kind of twenty-four-hour standby team?”

“Nothing like that. It’s about something important.”

“Then…”

“Sorry, but I think we’ll have to call it a night.”

“Don’t apologize. It’s not like we don’t understand each other’s circumstances.”

I set down my glass and stood. Then I gave Park Jihoon, who was looking at me apologetically, a light tap on the shoulder.

I had a good time tonight.

I meant it. Now that I had become famous in the modern world, there weren't many people left with whom I could have an ulterior-motive-free conversation like this.

I stopped him when he tried to follow me into the elevator.

"I'm heading out. Don't bother coming down just to see me off. Take care of your problem."

A faint smile touched Park Jihoon's lips.

"Okay. Let's meet again. Definitely."

With those final words, the elevator doors closed.

Park Jihoon stood before the window and looked down.

A lone figure was leaving the officetel[1489] entrance below, swallowed by the darkness.

"Hello? Mr. Jihoon? Mr. Jihoon?"

"Go ahead."

"Ah, we finally connected. You were listening, so why didn't you say anything…?"

"I think you've misunderstood something, Team Leader."

The other person's breathing faltered at the dry voice.

Park Jihoon lifted a crystal tumbler to his lips. Instead of the somaek[1490] he'd been drinking moments ago, amber whiskey rippled inside.

"From now on, wait until I speak. And stop trying to play boss with me."

Park Jihoon, Hunter of Team 1 in the Myeongdong Guild.

That was the affiliation printed on his business card.

But the Team Leader of Team 1 in the Myeongdong Guild remained silent on the other end of the phone.

They both knew the truth. That title was nothing more than a hollow position.

"You're not answering."

"…Understood."

"So what is it? This important report of yours?"

The Team Leader of Team 1 answered carefully.

"You know Team Leader Jung Hyunwoo, right? The one in charge of Team 8."

[1489] An officetel is a Korean mixed-use unit designed to function as both an office and a residence.

[1490] *Somaek* is a drink made by mixing soju, a Korean distilled spirit, with beer.

"Of course. He's skilled, but his flexibility isn't even half as impressive as his ability. That's the problem."

"It seems he's caught the scent."

"Really? He's more perceptive than I expected."

"Yes. But I wasn't sure how we should handle it…"

"What is there to think about? Schedule a raid for the earliest possible date. An A-rank one."

"You mean…"

"Team Leader, do you know how many Gate accidents happen every year? I don't. Neither does anyone else. Nobody cares."

"…"

Park Jihoon clicked his tongue.

"You're not answering again."

"Ah. Understood."

"And regarding the Peace Guild—or rather, the Jin Taekyung matter…"

Park Jihoon trailed off.

The face of the man who had smiled and tapped him on the shoulder came to mind.

I had a good time tonight.

It had been a sincere statement.

That only made Park Jihoon even less willing to stop.

"Mr. Jihoon?"

Park Jihoon tossed back the rest of his whiskey.

The crystal tumbler crumpled in his hand like a sheet of paper.

"I finished speaking with the higher-ups today. They find him irritating."

That was all. A single passing remark over dinner with *that person*. The matter had been as good as settled from that moment on.

"What? But this isn't really the right time for something like that…"

Park Jihoon's cold voice cut off the Team Leader's startled protest.

"Isn't it only natural for a gardener to pull weeds from the lawn? Your Guild Master has probably already heard the news. I'm hanging up."

Click.

The call ended.

In the silence that followed, Park Jihoon stared through the spotless window at the view outside.

Jin Taekyung was long gone.

Chapter 273

“Good morning!”

“Good morning!”

I felt like a mob boss. Every time I took a step, rookie Guild members bowed ninety degrees and greeted me from every direction.

They were fresh out of training camp, still wet behind the ears. In terms of years on the job, I was certainly their senior by a wide margin.

This industry does take seniority and junior status pretty seriously.

The problem was that some of the rookie Guild members were late-blooming Hunters older than me.

“It’s an honor to meet you!”

A rookie who looked well into his mid-thirties bowed, his eyes sparkling.

Then I saw the top of his head shining even brighter, and my heart ached.

“Right. Good luck…”

“Thank you!”

“Thank you!”

What are you, an echo?

And I wasn’t talking to you guys. You thick-haired bastards.

I clicked my tongue inwardly as I studied the rookies, then stopped when my gaze reached one young man.

That one might actually be useful.

He was the most promising of the new recruits. His aura was impressive, and every movement he made was as controlled as a martial artist’s.

Noticing my gaze, the young man grinned.

“Good morning, Senior.”

He was definitely different. Unlike the other rookies, he wasn’t nervous or obsequious.

In my experience, guys like him fell into one of two categories.

Either they had absolutely nothing to back up their pride, or they were confident in their own abilities.

The guy in front of me belonged to the latter.

“You there. What’s your name?”

“My name is Kim Jinsoo. I graduated at the top of the training camp’s B-rank course. I was also the first person to destroy a Golem’s core during this raid.”

“Really?”

“Yes. It was my first A-rank Gate, but it wasn’t as difficult as I expected.”

What an interesting guy.

He had no hesitation about gilding his own face. He was the type who would always make sure he got his share wherever he went.

When I stared at him, Kim Jinsoo gave me an easygoing smile.

“And you don’t need to speak so formally with me, Senior.”

“We just met. I’ll speak casually once we know each other better. The same goes for everyone else, so I’d appreciate it if you skipped the loud greetings from now on.”

“Yes!”

“I’ll keep that in mind, Senior!”

“…”

He hadn’t listened to a word I said.

The deafening noise echoed through the hallway, and the office door at the far end slowly opened.

A crisp white dress shirt and neatly pressed black slacks. There was only one Hunter in our Guild who came to work dressed like that.

“You’re all lively this morning.”

“Too lively, if you ask me.”

Like a scene from a commercial, Team Leader Choi held a coffee cup and jerked his chin toward the office.

“Come in and have some coffee. Let’s calm things down.”

The office was spacious and comfortable. Perhaps because it had been decorated to suit Team Leader Choi’s tastes, expensive furniture stood everywhere, and a silver nameplate sat on the desk.

Team Leader Choi Minwoo

Even the nameplate looks expensive.

Moving the Guild House and recruiting all those new Guild members must have cost a fortune. Apparently, it was true that the Peace Guild had extracted an astronomical settlement from the Star Guild, where Won Myunghoon had been Guild Master.

As I admired the nameplate, a cup of black coffee suddenly appeared in front of me.

Team Leader Choi followed my gaze.

“Would you like me to have one made for you? A nameplate.”

“I’m fine. I don’t have a position to put on it.”

“We can always create one. General Team Leader. Division Head. Whatever you want.”

“Anything?”

"Yes."

"Then I'll keep it modest. Guild Master."

"…"

"I'm joking. If I became Guild Master, I'd run the Guild into the ground."

Besides, even if I did become Guild Master, I'd obviously be nothing but a mascot—a puppet Guild Master. What would be the point?

I accepted the coffee and sat on the sofa. More than twenty newspapers were stacked on the glass table.

They ranged from major domestic dailies to foreign newspapers filled with writing I couldn't even begin to decipher. Just looking at them made my eyes spin.

"You actually read all of these?"

"I read them to keep track of overseas developments and collect industry information. It's nothing special. Knowing around five languages is enough to read them."

"…"

That was extremely special. Five languages? What kind of life had this man led?

Shaking my head in amazement, I glanced at one of the open newspapers.

A clear color photograph of a man who looked to be in his thirties caught my eye, along with several headlines in bold print.

- The Late Hunter Jung Hyunwoo (pictured)
- Accidents Continue: Gates Remain Deadly Even for A-Rank Hunters
- Myeongdong Guild Expresses Regret over Unexpected Death…

It looked like there had been another accident.

The Myeongdong Guild? That's Jihoon's Guild.

Just as I was about to take a closer look, Team Leader Choi elegantly tilted his coffee cup and continued.

"The Peace Guild will continue to grow. We've already recruited twenty B-rank Hunters and thirty C-rank or lower Hunters. That kind of growth is unprecedented in Korea's long-stagnant market."

Just as he said, the Peace Guild was growing at a terrifying rate.

Only about four months had passed since the Guild was founded, but if we maintained this momentum, we could easily call ourselves a mid-sized Guild.

Of course, we still have far fewer Hunters than other mid-sized Guilds.

That was because we hadn't recruited more yet, not because we couldn't.

The Guild website had already gone down from excessive traffic. I'd heard that hundreds of job inquiries poured in every day.

"And I played a major role in that. I'm the number one contributor."

"That's true."

Team Leader Choi continued smoothly.

“It is true, but I’m not giving you a bonus.”

“…You’re quick to catch on.”

I’d tested the waters just in case, but he hadn’t taken the bait.

As he watched me silently smack my lips, Team Leader Choi smiled.

“However, I’ll consider it favorably if you do me one favor.”

“What favor?”

“I’d like you to take charge of the rookie Guild members for a while.”

“…The rookies?”

“Yes. We were very selective when we recruited them, and they’re all talented, but they’re still rough around the edges.”

“Of course they are. They’re beginners.”

No matter how much training someone went through, a real battle felt completely different from the training camp.

There was a reason people said a lower-rank Hunter with ten years of experience was better than a higher-rank Hunter fresh out of training camp.

“But why ask me? There are other people here.”

“I already spoke to Butler Kim and Song-i this morning. I suggested that we take turns teaching the rookies.”

“What did they say?”

“They agreed. Gladly, without the slightest hesitation.”

“…What about Uncle Kkeokjeong?”

“I haven’t been able to ask him yet. It’s long past his usual arrival time, and he isn’t answering his phone.”

Team Leader Choi checked the time and continued.

“Wouldn’t it be a good idea? The rookie Guild members are hoping that Mr. Jin Taekyung will teach them, too. Most of them applied to our Guild because of you.”

“I appreciate the flattery, but…”

I scratched the back of my head.

Dark Heaven had revealed its fangs in Murim, and Jeok Cheongang was still unconscious.

Even if I spent thirty days in the modern world, only three hours would pass in Murim. I had time to spare, but with A-rank Gates to clear, teaching a bunch of greenhorns wasn’t exactly the most rewarding use of it.

If I was going to spend that time on something else, I’d be a hundred times better off with my family.

“Leave me out of it. From the Guild’s perspective, wouldn’t it be more efficient for me to clear another A-rank Gate instead of teaching those guys?”

“More efficient…”

“Yes. Efficiency.”

“Then I suppose it can’t be helped.”

A sinister smile curled Team Leader Choi’s lips.

“I’ll be counting on you with our rookie Guild members.”

“What?”

“All the A-rank Gates are booked solid. You won’t get into one for at least a week.”

“Don’t lie to me! You scam artist!”

“If you don’t believe me, see for yourself.”

I snatched the paper Team Leader Choi held out. It was densely packed with the reservation schedules for A-rank Gates across the country.

Damn it. He was telling the truth.

“I’ll give you a two-hundred-percent performance bonus this month. You get to go on raids and teach your juniors. How wholesome.”

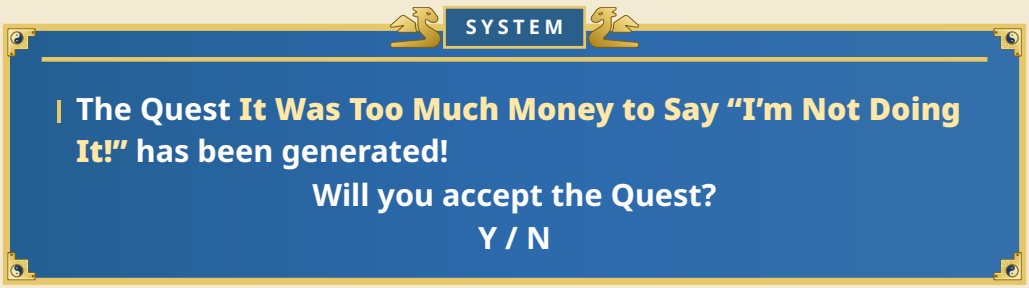
“…”

“Or you can stay home and do nothing.”

The corners of Team Leader Choi’s mouth rose in an infuriating smile.

I was just about to shout, *I’m not doing it!*, when a System notification rang.

Ding.

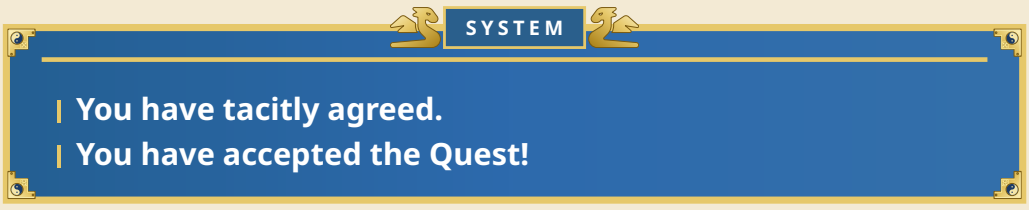


“What do you say?”

“…”

“I’ll take that as a yes and get the rookies ready. I’ve already reserved several B-rank Gates.”

Ding.



Goddamn it.

—Grrrrr.

The monsters' harsh breathing closed in from every direction. Twenty pairs of anxious eyes swept their surroundings.

Huff. Huff.

Their breathing grew ragged, and their hands turned white around their shields and weapons.

Perched on a branch high above the ground, I watched the scene unfold.

My face was expressionless, but my mind was occupied by a serious dilemma.

What should I have for dinner?

Galbi,[1491] or whole boiled duck for the first time in ages?

Both were too good to pass up…

"Hold the line!"

"What are the damage dealers doing? Damage dealers!"

The shrill screams drew my attention back to the chaos below.

More than a dozen Lycanthropes were charging the shield wall and hammering against it. The pale-faced tanks were being driven steadily backward.

Of course they're getting pushed back. They're trying to overpower the monsters head-on.

It wasn't entirely the tanks' fault, though. The damage dealers were so flustered that they weren't doing their jobs, either.

If they had launched suppressive attacks at the right moments, this situation would never have happened.

I'd warned them several times before the raid began, but they were still making the same mistakes.

That line is about to break.

The moment I thought it, the shield wall collapsed amid a chorus of screams.

A gap opened in an instant. One of the most agile-looking Lycanthropes charged through with a characteristic roar.

Its bright yellow predator's eyes fixed on the healers sheltering behind the shield wall.

—Graaaargh!

—Awoooooo!

To me, it sounded no different from a dog barking, but these rookie Hunters, who were only beginning their second raid, were terrified.

"Aaaah!"

"Eeeek!"

The mage and healer's screams shook the dark forest.

[1491] Galbi means ribs in Korean; as a dish, it commonly refers to grilled beef or pork ribs.

It's already noisy enough. Those screams are going to draw another twenty or so over here.

I memorized the faces of the two people who had screamed.

From now on, their nickname is the Pied Pipers.

"Senior! Senior Jin Taekyung!"

"Please help us, Senior!"

Several round faces looked up at me and cried out desperately.

The front line had already collapsed, and the rookies had nothing behind them but an enormous boulder.

The Lycanthropes closed in triumphantly, tightening their encirclement.

How did the monsters end up being better at forming ranks than they are?

I rubbed the sleep from the corner of my eye and answered.

"I told you. If I help, your skills won't improve."

"We don't care if they improve!"

"Well, I do. You know what happens if you make a habit of getting help? You'll make a habit of shitting the bed during raids, too."

"We still don't want to die like this!"

"But… nobody wants to die, you know?"

"Please help us!"

"Don't give up. Keep fighting. You can do it!"

"Please save us!"

"By the way, what should I have for dinner—galbi[1492] or boiled duck?"

"Hey, you fucking bastard!"

It was the balding rookie from that morning. The admiring light that had shone as brightly as his crown was gone, replaced by a gaze full of fury.

"Get down here, you young bastard…"

Thud!

A tank came flying in from somewhere and crashed into him, sending them both sailing into the distance.

The momentum had effectively shifted to the monsters. I was wondering whether it was time to step in when—

Shhk!

—Kauuugh…

A flash of light streaked through the air, and one of the Lycanthropes groaned. Blood gushed from its gaping throat before it crumpled to the ground.

The young man who had landed the precise, powerful strike shouted at the top of his lungs.

[1492] Galbi means ribs in Korean; as a dish, it commonly refers to grilled beef or pork ribs.

“Formation Three!”

His booming voice snapped the others back to their senses one by one.

Soon, the twenty Hunters had re-formed their ranks and begun advancing slowly.

At their head stood Kim Jinsoo.

“Keep pushing! Archers, get your skills ready!”

That kid has potential.

I let out a quiet laugh and jumped down from the tree. Then I swung my spear at the dozens of Lycanthropes drawn by the sound of battle.

Whoooosh!

“You did well.”

“Thank you, Senior!”

Kim Jinsoo grinned and bowed. Behind him, I saw three people with their heads pressed into the ground.

Two were the Pied Pipers, and the other was the balding rookie.

I’d given the balding rookie the special privilege of holding the push-up position.

I had to help him protect what little hair he had left…

“Keep it up next time. You’ll improve quickly.”

“Yes. I won’t disappoint you, Senior.”

“Then go get some rest, Jinsoo. We have another raid in two hours.”

Team Leader Choi had really gone all out. He’d scheduled three raids in a single day.

I was grinding my teeth inwardly when the phone in my pocket began to vibrate.

Designer-Brand Junkie

What was this? Had we developed telepathy?

Still baffled, I answered the call. Team Leader Choi’s urgent voice struck my ear.

“Taekyung. Come to the hospital in Ilsan right now!”

Hospital?

Chapter 274

Hospital? Why so suddenly?

I was just about to ask what had happened when the call ended amid the sound of hurried footsteps.

I tried calling back two or three times, but it was no use.

—The number you have dialed cannot be reached. After the beep, you will be connected to voicemail…

I hung up when the automated message began repeating. Unease crept into my chest.

This was a first. Team Leader Choi was always calm, but he had sounded frantic.

Could it be…?

No. Don’t jump to conclusions already.

This wasn’t the time to think. It was time to move.

Ilsan Hospital. He said Ilsan Hospital.

I grabbed my things and left the changing room. The rookies waiting outside turned their heads when I appeared.

Kim Jinsoo, who had been chatting animatedly in the middle of the group, sprang to his feet.

“Ah, Senior. Are we leaving right away?”

“No. Something urgent has come up.”

The timing could have been worse. There were two hours until the next raid, and thankfully, the next Gate was nearby. It wouldn’t take long to get there.

“Mr. Kim Jinsoo.”

“Yes.”

“You’re the acting team leader for the next two hours.”

“What?”

“Take the others to the next Gate. And don’t start the raid under any circumstances until I get there.”

Kim Jinsoo nodded, looking dazed. I gave him a light tap on the shoulder, then hurried out of the building.

I climbed into a taxi waiting for a passenger, told the driver where to go, and immediately started making calls.

Pick up. Please pick up.

Ring. Ring.

The longer the phone rang, the more anxious I became.

Just as I was about to hang up and try again—

Click.

"Hey, son."

"What? Is that my brother?"

"Be quiet. Don't play with the phone while you're eating."

"Seriously? Is what Mom's holding a brick instead of a phone?"

"You little brat!"

"Whew."

Thank God. It wasn't them.

The tension left me all at once when I heard my family's voices on the other end of the line.

Mom asked what was going on, so I gave her a vague excuse and hung up.

Then it must be a problem with the Guild.

Who was in trouble?

If Team Leader Choi wasn't answering, Butler Kim would have the clearest picture of the situation.

But then someone else's face flashed through my mind—how quiet he had become lately, and the heavy expression he'd been wearing.

Uncle Kkeokjeong.

My guess was right.

When I called the number saved in my phone, I was greeted not by Im Kkeokjeong's gruff voice, but by a cold automated message.

—The phone is turned off. After the beep…

I raced to the hospital. Song Song, who had apparently been contacted in advance, was waiting outside with an anxious look on her face.

"You're here?"

"Tell me while we walk."

The hospital's distinctive smell hit me as soon as we passed through the revolving doors.

Civilians, Hunters, hospital staff—the place was packed. We pushed our way through the crowd.

A few people who recognized me pulled out their phones and started taking pictures.

"Hey, hey. Look over there."

"That's Jin Taekyung."

"Jin Taekyung? Lord Fuck?"[1493]

"Wow, he looks incredible in person."

[1493] Lord Fuck is an online nickname coined after Taekyung's accidental profanity was broadcast.

I forced down the stress surging inside me.

As the crowd parted before us like the Red Sea, I whispered to Song Song.

“What happened?”

“I don’t know all the details, either…”

“Just tell me what you do know.”

She bit her lip.

“He seemed to have a lot on his mind lately.”

“On his mind?”

“You know how things are. The Guild keeps growing, and talented young rookies keep joining…”

“That’s enough. I get it.”

Im Kkeokjeong had been with the Peace Guild since its earliest days. But he was also the only D-rank Hunter among us.

Once the Peace Guild began drawing media attention because of me, people had started talking about him, too.

They called him the Guild’s only weak link. Some even left hateful comments telling him to quit instead of trying to ride our coattails.

Im Kkeokjeong had laughed heartily and stopped the rest of us from getting angry over it.

But…

“Whew.”

My chest felt tight.

I had promised myself that I would always look after my people, yet I had failed to pay enough attention to someone so close to me.

“So what happened after yesterday’s raid?”

“Apparently, he went out drinking alone and got into an argument.”

“Go on.”

“I heard he was completely drunk when the fight started… He was badly injured.”

My heart dropped.

Strangers could run their mouths about him being a low-rank Hunter or whatever else they wanted, but Im Kkeokjeong was a D-rank Hunter with twenty years of experience.

Even ten grown men attacking at once wouldn’t be able to bring him down.

“So the other side were Hunters.”

Song Song gave a small nod.

“How badly was he hurt? Is it serious?”

“His treatment is finished for now, but…”

Unable to continue, Song Song hesitated and came to a stop.

A sign reading *Special Treatment Ward* swayed above her head.

This wasn't a ward where doctors treated patients. It was staffed by practitioners known as healers.

That alone showed how severe his injuries were.

"You'd better see for yourself."

The words left Song Song like a sigh as she slid open the hospital-room door.

Rattle.

A harsh medicinal smell washed over me, and I saw three people pacing around the bed.

Team Leader Choi. Butler Kim. And a middle-aged woman I assumed was Im Kkeokjeong's wife.

My heart pounded as I approached the bed.

"…Uncle?"

Hhhk. Hhk.

Only faint, ragged breathing answered me. Im Kkeokjeong lay beneath the stark white sheets with an oxygen mask over his face.

And then…

The hairy arm he always wrapped around me in a crushing hug had been cleanly severed below the elbow.

The silence stretched on.

Even after leaving the hospital room and climbing to the rooftop, I couldn't figure out what I should say first.

I listened quietly as Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim explained what had happened. At last, I opened my mouth.

"Where are those bastards now?"

Everyone there knew exactly who I meant.

Team Leader Choi's lips moved. Then he silently shook his head.

No way.

"You didn't catch them?"

"No. All three fled the scene."

"What about the CCTV footage? They were drinking at a store. Their faces should have been recorded."

"The investigators have already examined it. They have the results."

Security cameras these days offered practically the same image quality as regular cameras. If the bastards' faces had been captured clearly, catching them should only be a matter of time.

Hunters and Awakened people were few enough in number to make them easy to track down.

“Then that’s fine. We’ll find those bastards right away and—”

“They say their identities are unknown.”

“What?”

Had I heard him wrong?

When I stared at him in confusion, Team Leader Choi continued with a sigh.

“Their identities are unknown. Apparently, they aren’t any Awakened or Hunters registered as existing in this country.”

“…Could they be ethnic Koreans from China? Or Chinese or Japanese?”

“No. According to the witnesses, the suspects were definitely Korean. They were also the ones who started the argument.”

“Then what the hell is going on…?”

Butler Kim, who had been silently listening to my conversation with Team Leader Choi, suddenly spoke.

“They may be Black Hunters.”

Black Hunters?

Even the name sounded filthy. Butler Kim continued in a low voice.

“Not every Awakened person is registered with the Gate Management Agency and the Association.”

So that was what this unfamiliar term meant?

I rubbed my throbbing temple.

“Aren’t those just unregistered Awakened people?”

In modern society, Awakened people were both powerful shields against Gates and dangerous blades that had to be handled with care.

Even the lowest-rank Hunter possessed strength far beyond that of an average person.

That was why Awakened people were always kept under strict supervision.

Even if they had no intention of becoming Hunters, their names were still placed on the list of Awakened people.

The only way off that list was to die.

An *unregistered Awakened person* was someone who had failed to register with the Association within the designated period.

Of course, they were sometimes called something else.

Madman.

There was a reason unregistered Awakened people were treated like lunatics.

If they didn’t voluntarily report their Awakening within a month, they stopped being Awakened people and became inmates instead.

To hell with suspended sentences or any other bullshit. They were thrown straight into a prison for Awakened criminals, and when they got out, they even received an electronic ankle monitor as a free gift.

Who would be insane enough to gamble their entire life like that?

“Are there still lunatics like that these days?”

“There always have been, and there still are. Why else do you think crime continues to exist?”

“So the people who attacked Uncle Kkeokjeong were unregistered Awakened people. Then how do we find them…?”

Butler Kim gently cut me off.

“They’re Black Hunters.”

“Yes. In other words, unregistered Awakened people.”

“They’re different.”

Butler Kim stroked his neatly trimmed beard and continued.

“Hunter Jin Taekyung, what do you think is the greatest difference between an Awakened person and a Hunter?”

The question came out of nowhere. I felt like we were going around in circles.

If the person asking hadn’t been Butler Kim, I might have said something.

Suppressing the anger boiling inside me, I answered.

“Training. Just because someone owns a gun doesn’t make them a hunter.”

“The same distinction applies to unregistered Awakened people and Black Hunters.”

“So what you’re saying is…”

Butler Kim nodded.

“Exactly. An unregistered Awakened person who has received the same systematic training as a Hunter. That is a Black Hunter.”

For a moment, my mind went blank.

It was a very simple concept when you thought about it, but I had never considered it before.

And for good reason.

“How is that possible?”

Unregistered Awakened people were felons. Where would they get weapons, and who would provide them with systematic training?

“Are criminal organizations training Black Hunters or something?”

“Criminal organizations… That’s half right and half wrong.”

“Then what is it?”

The answer burst tersely from Team Leader Choi’s mouth.

“Guilds.”

"…What?"

"Money gathers wherever people gather. And wherever money piles up, conflict inevitably follows. Do you really believe today's Guilds exist purely to protect the world from the monsters inside Gates?"

I couldn't answer.

I hadn't become a Hunter to protect the world, either.

The Great Cataclysm was already a thing of the past. When people thought of Hunters, they no longer imagined noble duty or a spirit of self-sacrifice.

They envied the money and fame Hunters possessed, and the people who grew up watching that became Hunters themselves.

Guilds were nothing more than collections of those Hunters.

"Do you know the country's corporate rankings? From first to tenth place? On the surface, they're all private companies, but in reality, they're little more than puppets of massive Guilds. Things aren't much different overseas."

Team Leader Choi let out a cold laugh.

Only then did I finally begin to recover from the shock.

"Is… is all of that really true?"

"You once asked me why I left Ares Guild."

Team Leader Choi said nothing more, but I understood what he meant.

They were all pieces of shit in the same cesspool.

To them, Black Hunters were like daggers concealed up their sleeves. No one knew they existed.

No, they might know and simply pretend not to.

While I was still reeling, another unanswered question came to mind.

"Fine. Let's say all of that is true."

I took a deep breath, cooling my head.

"But why did those Black Hunters specifically target Uncle Kkeokjeong? Why go this far just to keep a Guild so far beneath them in check?"

"Taekyung."

Team Leader Choi cut me off and licked his parched lips.

There was something strange in his eyes. He was looking at me as if I were a greenhorn.

It felt as though I had gone back to the day I first became a Hunter.

"You're naive."

Before I could answer, he continued.

"This place is crawling with monsters. It's the kind of place where one bothersome person—or even an entire Guild—can simply be erased. Get rid of that half-baked common sense."

That cold sentence pierced my chest.

Chapter 275

You're naive.

That one sentence I'd heard the day before wouldn't leave my mind.

I sat in the caregiver's chair beside the bed, staring blankly at the humidifier spraying mist. Then a thought suddenly occurred to me, and I said it aloud.

"No. It wasn't naivety."

Murim was a world that lived up to the phrase *a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords*.

Bloodshed was commonplace, and death was part of daily life. Might made right, and whoever survived was the winner.

Whenever I witnessed Murim's cruelty, I thought of the modern world.

An organized welfare system and laws. People's sense of ethics. A civilization incomparably more advanced than Murim.

But I had been wrong.

"It wasn't that I was naive. I was just stupid."

Murim people wore swords at their waists, but modern people hid daggers up their sleeves.

Monsters weren't confined to Gates. They existed outside them, too.

People wrapped in expensive clothes and wholesome public images who ruled over the concrete jungle. The moment those bastards began drawing the daggers hidden in their sleeves, they revealed themselves as the monsters outside the Gates.

Like Won Myunghoon.

I'd been too soft in my thinking. Even though I knew the world was unfair and fucked-up, I hadn't been able to let go of my complacency.

This is the modern world. A democratic society in the twenty-first century.

There might be a vicious struggle to prove one's abilities, but I'd believed something like this could never happen here.

And this is what that got me.

I stared at Im Kkeokjeong sleeping on the bed. Both arms, severed below the elbows, had been treated with recovery magic from a high-ranking healer and advanced potions.

He probably wouldn't have much trouble with daily life, but there was no guarantee he could return as a Hunter. Potions weren't a cure-all.

Which bastard was behind this?

Various thoughts swam through my cold mind.

Who had sent the Black Hunter, and why? What were they after?

Cutting off Im Kkeokjeong's arms could have been a warning to stop here. Or it could have been the opening shot.

I'll find out what they meant soon enough.

Until then, I had no intention of sitting around and waiting.

Neither did Team Leader Choi.

"Get some rest, Uncle."

I had just pulled the rumpled blanket over Im Kkeokjeong when—

Bzzzz.

A vibration broke the silence, and my smartphone lit up the darkness.

A short text message from Team Leader Choi.

> **Team Leader Choi:** Come to the Guild House.

I left the hospital as soon as I read the message. It was the dead of night, and two people were waiting for me at the Guild House after everyone else had gone home.

"Ah, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Welcome."

Team Leader Choi and Song Song.

Butler Kim, whom I'd naturally expected to be there, was nowhere to be seen.

Team Leader Choi noticed my gaze and spoke first.

"He stepped out for a moment."

"Really?"

It was unusual for Butler Kim to leave Team Leader Choi's side when he usually followed him like a shadow, but that wasn't important right now.

I got straight to the point.

"What happened?"

"I should offer you a cup of coffee before I explain, but… take a look at this first."

Instead of a coffee cup, Team Leader Choi held out his smartphone. The screen displayed the country's largest online portal.

His long finger tapped an internet article, and a stream of articles divided into different categories appeared.

Among them, I skimmed the article at the very top.

> [The Judiciary Bows Before the Fame the Public Has Created. Where Is the Fairness?]

> [United Party Supreme Council Member Assemblywoman Yoon Seoyoon: “A Death Brought About by One Individual’s Rash Actions. Won Myunghoon Should Have Faced the Judgment of the Law.” Strong Condemnation…]
>
> [Self-Defense or Murder?]

The articles dominated the politics and society sections. They didn’t mention my name, but it was obvious who they were talking about.

“When was this posted?”

“An hour ago. And it already has over a hundred thousand views and more than five thousand comments.”

“An hour ago? That would’ve been around four in the morning.”

“Apparently, netizens are more diligent than we thought. Or perhaps I should say the paid commenters are.”

“Interesting.”

Team Leader Choi took a sip of coffee that had gone as cold as the smile on my lips.

“There’s an even more interesting article.”

“More interesting than this?”

“Scroll down a little. It’ll be more than you expected, Taekyung.”

He was right. My finger stopped moving before I realized it.

I stared silently at the bold headline.

> [Exclusive Preview of Interview with Former Colleague K: “Famous Hunter J Is a Vile Human Being.”]

When I tapped the article, a preview video of an interview lasting just over three minutes appeared. After a fifteen-second advertisement for a cosmetics brand, the screen filled with the image of a potbellied man in a sharp suit.

His face had been lightly pixelated, but I recognized him at a glance.

“Ha.”

The moment I realized who the middle-aged man—or rather, “former colleague K”—was, a hollow laugh escaped me.

That face was all too familiar. Someone I’d thought I would never see again was right there on the screen.

“I didn’t expect to see him again like this.”

Song Song, looking at the phone over my shoulder, asked, “You really know him?”

“Of course. How could I not?”

“If things were bad enough for him to give this shitty interview, you obviously didn’t get along.”

“No.”

"Then were you close?"

"It's not that…"

What word could describe the relationship between that man and me? I thought about it for a moment before answering.

"It was fucking awful."

"Oh."

No matter how I thought about it, those words fit perfectly.

Our relationship had been that terrible. Considering everything we had been through together, it was almost strange that we had never crossed blades.

I stared at the face that had somehow grown even fatter since the last time I'd seen him.

Mr. Common Sense. Long time no see.

Kim Sangshik, Team Leader of the Sopung Guild.

Back when I was an F-Grade Hunter, he had been the one who goaded the Guild Master into firing me.

The last time I'd seen him was when I ran into him at the Association while getting my Grade reassessed. And now, here he was again.

I heard he got fired from the Guild afterward.

Kim Sangshik was short on ability and overflowing with greed. Despite his name, he was short on common sense, too. He'd gone around doing every idiotic thing imaginable until the Guild finally fired him.

He was the very definition of a petty little man, so there was no doubt he'd been grinding his teeth at the thought of me ever since.

That was probably why he had even filmed an interview like this.

Let's hear what kind of bullshit he's spouting.

Right on cue, the reporter began asking questions.

"I hear you have something to say about the recently famous Hunter J. First, is it true that you were his former colleague?"

Kim Sangshik nodded with an uncharacteristically serious expression.

"That is absolutely true. I was Jin Tae… No, I was J's direct supervisor."

"More specifically?"

"He was on my team. I became team leader after the Gate accident two years ago. I was also the one who informed J of his dismissal this summer."

"Oh dear. Was there a reason?"

"There wasn't just one reason."

Kim Sangshik then launched into an indignant tirade about why he had fired me.

Every single excuse was a gem of bullshit, but his final exchange with the reporter was the crowning touch.

"I was falsely accused of employment corruption and driven out of the Guild where I had worked for more than twenty years. But I did not fire J for personal gain."

"Are you saying there was another reason?"

"Yes."

There had been a reason they had released only a three-minute preview. Kim Sangshik ended it with the solemn expression of a martyr for the nation.

"During the mutated Gate accident two years ago, J threw his teammates to the monsters as prey and fled. He is the kind of man who won't hesitate to do any ugly and dirty thing to survive…"

I couldn't properly hear what came after that.

Even after the video ended with a caption promising that the full interview would be released soon, I continued staring silently at the screen.

As if Kim Sangshik might leap out of it if I stared long enough.

Team Leader Choi broke the heavy silence.

"What did you think?"

Ah, what did I think?

Well. I felt like I'd been clubbed in the back of the head, but part of me wanted to laugh. At the same time, something was boiling in my gut.

"Very interesting. Just like you said, Team Leader."

"I laughed when I first saw it, too. I have a rough idea of what K—or rather, Kim Sangshik—is like. The problem is…"

"The public won't find it very funny."

"Exactly."

The comments section was already on the verge of exploding.

There were more than ten thousand comments now, and I didn't need to read them all. The most upvoted comment caught my eye.

> ㄴ **(Best comment):** I knew it. I heard it through the grapevine and thought, *No way,* but I always had a feeling this would blow up someday.

What vine? And what the hell is supposed to blow up?

I didn't know what kind of asshole had written it, but it was a relief he wasn't standing in front of me.

If he had been, I would have made sure that at the very least, he heard the next rumor from the overpass to the Yellow Springs.[1494]

"Well, I don't think there's any need to read more."

[1494] The Yellow Springs is a traditional East Asian name for the realm of the dead.

I closed the comments with a hollow laugh.

Team Leader Choi took back his smartphone, loosely folded his arms, and spoke.

“This is organized. It’s clear now that they planned to send the Black Hunter from the very beginning.”

“And they’re the ones creating the hostile public opinion, too.”

“That’s how people are. Once someone starts muddying the waters in earnest, it’s hard to keep your bearings.”

“And I doubt there will be even a single line in the news about Uncle Kkeokjeong being attacked in the middle of all this.”

“You understand the situation well.”

“If I didn’t, I’d be a fucking idiot. Has the investigation team handling the case said anything?”

Team Leader Choi shook his head slightly.

“Don’t tell me they’re in on it, too.”

“There seems to be outside pressure. The CCTV footage is in the other side’s hands, too.”

“Didn’t you say there were witnesses?”

“We’ve lost contact with all three.”

That’s just fantastic.

My fist clenched without me realizing it, and my knuckles cracked.

“They’re really coming at us with a plan.”

“They seem intent on isolating you completely. The interview with Mr. Kim Sangshik is part of that.”

We weren’t dealing with some Third Rate media company that made its money selling gossip.

This was one of the country’s ten largest media outlets.

They would wrap even the most ludicrous bullshit in glossy packaging and present it as credible. Then they would use money and power to lend it even more weight.

For example… testimony from people who knew me well.

“Looks like I’ll get to see my old coworkers again. Though I guess they’ll be hard to recognize once their faces are pixelated.”

I asked Team Leader Choi, who was looking at me with an unreadable expression,

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

“As I recall, Jin Taekyung had a good reputation within the Sopung Guild.”

“I got along with everyone. It was such a dinky little Guild.”

“Then why did you think that?”

“Because there’s one thing that works on everyone. This. And this.”

I brought my thumb and index finger together and wiggled them.

In the end, it all came down to cash. Money was everything.

And for Hunters who risked their lives to make money, the temptation would be even stronger.

“Maybe it’s because I’ve been stabbed in the back so many times in a row, but… these are people I spent seven years laughing and joking around with, and I still can’t trust them.”

If this had happened a few days ago, I might have naively believed in my old coworkers.

But not anymore. The world where dreams, friendship, and common sense meant anything had already vanished from my mind.

“Looking at how the article made it into the politics and society section, it seems like they greased some lawmaker’s palm, too. You think they couldn’t buy off a few low-Grade Hunters who are struggling to make ends meet?”

“…”

“It’s obvious. I’ll become the worst bastard alive and get carved up all over the internet. The image I’ve built up until now will come crashing down, and our Guild will come crashing down with it.”

Team Leader Choi, who had been wearing that strange expression the entire time, let out a quiet laugh.

“You’ve improved a little. You can think like a jaded adult now.”

“Are you taking back what you said yesterday about me being naive?”

“I’ll decide after I see what you do from here.”

“What?”

“We can’t just stand by and let them do this to us.”

As he spoke, he tapped his smartphone screen. The phone rang, and someone answered.

“I found it. The tail.”

Butler Kim’s low, smooth voice flowed through the speaker.

Chapter 276

The middle-aged man looked like any other ordinary guy from the neighborhood.

A bluish shadow of stubble ran from his sideburns to his chin. His practical hiking clothes bulged around his belly.

At the crack of dawn, he finished stretching with sleep still heavy in his eyes, then began jogging slowly along a path between the rice paddies.

“One-two, one-two,” he chanted in the hearty rhythm peculiar to middle-aged men everywhere.

He was the “tail” Butler Kim had found.

“Are you sure this is the man?”

Inside an equally ordinary minivan, Song Song watched the footage Butler Kim had recorded with magic and muttered doubtfully.

“He looks normal.”

“Wouldn’t it be stranger if he looked extraordinary? It’s not like you can recognize a Black Hunter the way you can a ninth-grade civil servant.[1495]”

“Still, that man looks way too normal. Is there something only combat Hunters can recognize?”

“There is.”

I stared intently at the middle-aged man as he finished his jog and entered the mansion.

All I was looking at was a recording, so I couldn’t sense his internal energy. But no matter how talented an actor was, some tiny movement would always give them away.

And I had the eye to see through an act.

“A Peak master…”

“Hm?”

Song Song wasn’t the only one who reacted to my mutter.

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim looked at me as if to ask what I meant, so I continued.

“…I mean, an A-rank Hunter.”

“You seemed to say something else. Did you say ‘Peak master’?”

“Nope. You must have misheard.”

At times like this, the only answer was absolute denial. If I said I hadn’t said it, what could they do?

Their doubtful looks lasted only a moment before Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim nodded in agreement with my assessment.

[1495] In South Korea, grade 9 is the entry-level rank for civil servants.

“I also believe he is an A-rank Hunter.”

“From what I observed, he ranks fairly high even among A-rank Hunters. I had no choice but to keep my distance because I thought he might detect the surveillance magic.”

Butler Kim’s assessment made sense. He was a battle-hardened veteran of the Great Cataclysm and had observed the man in person.

But Team Leader Choi had a far keener eye than I’d expected.

This wasn’t something just anyone could recognize.

Well, that isn’t important right now.

I asked what I was most curious about.

“But how did you find him? I heard the investigation team had collected all the nearby CCTV footage.”

“We went and retrieved it again.”

No, I meant, how did you manage that?

Before I could ask, Team Leader Choi pressed his thumb and index finger together to form a circle.

“You said this works on just about everyone, Taekyung.”

“Ah…”

“It’s an immutable truth. I’ve made frequent use of it myself for some time.”

So he had bribed someone on the investigation team.

Considering Team Leader Choi’s generosity, whoever it was must have made quite a haul.

“Didn’t you say there was outside pressure?”

“When there’s outside pressure, you give them enough money to withstand it.”

Impressive.

But judging by what he said next, even money had its limits.

“It appears that someone fairly powerful has gotten involved. Normally, they should have told us everything without much resistance, but perhaps they were frightened. No matter how much money we fed them, they refused to talk. The CCTV footage was the best we could get.”

“And that man was caught on it?”

“Yes. There were slight discrepancies, possibly because he used an artifact enchanted with Illusion magic, but there’s no doubt it was him.”

I had expected as much, but it seemed the people pulling the strings wielded considerable power.

They had greased the palm of a supreme council member from a political party and manipulated public opinion online as easily as breathing. Even the police and prosecutors—corrupt enough to accept bribes—were afraid to make a move.

It has to be one of the major Guilds.

A major Guild ranked among the top twenty could pull this off. They were effectively corporate giants operating under the name of a Guild.

They had even cultivated an illegal private army of Black Hunters. That told me everything I needed to know.

“So what does that bastard do?”

“He’s a city dweller who fulfilled his dream of moving to the countryside and becoming a farmer.”

Butler Kim smoothly added one more sentence as he handed me a tablet.

“On the surface.”

The tablet contained everything about the “tail.”

He was now in his mid-forties. He had amassed a considerable fortune in the stock market over a decade ago, but after repeatedly collapsing from a chronic illness, he had decided to move to the countryside.

“A chronic illness?”

“We even have the hospital records.”

What kind of chronic illness could an A-rank Hunter have?

I snorted and flicked through the medical records.

“I’ll bet my left wrist that all of this is bullshit.”

Team Leader Choi nodded as if that went without saying.

“Then I’ll bet Jin Taekyung’s right wrist.”

“…”

Was this lunatic serious? Why was he betting my wrist?

Casually ignoring my incredulous stare, Team Leader Choi continued.

“In any case, on paper, he’s a perfectly ordinary citizen. Apparently, he was sociable from the day he first settled there. He throws a village feast once every two weeks, so the villagers stopped treating him like an outsider long ago.”

“And no one suspects him in a remote mountain village?”

“He’s a rich, good-natured man.”

“It’s the perfect place to hide and do things. For example, train Black Hunters.”

I examined the final image closely.

A picturesque two-story house. The building itself looked relatively small compared to the spacious yard.

A luxury SUV and a sedan were parked beside the gray stone wall.

How many people are inside?

There had been three men in the group that attacked Im Kkeokjeong. They had no reason to scatter like the Dragon Balls,[1496] so I had to assume they were all inside that house.

[1496]The Dragon Balls are magical objects scattered across the world in the Japanese series *Dragon Ball*.

Ah, wait. Hold on.

"You said he throws a village feast once every two weeks."

"Yes. Each time, he orders a large quantity of food from outside, but… Ah!"

The village feasts were probably a cover for procuring food.

There might be a lot more of them than I thought.

Did he keep the rest crammed into a basement to train?

Or were they hidden somewhere in the dense forest surrounding the house?

Personally, I hoped they were all huddled together in the basement.

That would make things easier.

"Approaching carelessly could backfire. So for today, we should stop here and—"

"Yes. It's about time we got started."

I pulled my hood low and opened the car door.

"I'll be back."

"Pardon?"

"The three of you can follow in twenty minutes. It should be almost over by then."

All three of them stared at me in bewilderment.

Butler Kim, the most experienced among them, spoke first.

"Hunter Jin Taekyung. There is nothing more frightening than an enemy whose capabilities you have not assessed."

"Yes. I know."

"I understand that your skills are exceptional, but…"

Butler Kim continued in a grave voice.

"There could be dozens of A-rank Hunters like the man I observed waiting for you."

"It's fine. Honestly, the Three Idiots looked stronger than that guy."

"…?"

"Don't worry about it. He just reminded me of some people I know."

Song Song asked incredulously, "You're thinking about people you know at a time like this?"

"No. I'm always thinking about you."

"Eek."

"Be quiet before I punish you with a confession."

"Aah!"

Whew. I'm fucking cool. No wonder women run screaming.

I was about to step out of the minivan after chalking up another easy win when Team Leader Choi spoke.

"I want to stop you, but I can't."

His expression was impossible to describe.

“Every crazy thing you’ve done has always succeeded.”

“You’ve got me figured out. Then move exactly as I said. It’ll all be over within an hour at most.”

“Black Hunters… Those men have been trained to hunt humans, not monsters. Be careful.”

I couldn’t hold back a short laugh.

“Good. That happens to be my specialty, too.”

“Pardon?”

Leaving the wide-eyed Team Leader Choi behind, I stepped outside.

Beneath a rural night sky strewn with stars, I drew the cool air deep into my lungs and stretched.

As I walked toward the Black Hunters’ base, shrouded in darkness in the distance, I was no longer Hunter Jin Taekyung.

I had become Jin Taekyung, a man of Murim.

Grrrrr.

A beast’s eyes flashed in the pitch-black darkness.

I directed my killing intent at the two Tosa mastiffs baring their teeth at me from behind the iron bars.

“If I hear you bark, you’re becoming dog-meat soup.”

Unless the dogs had attended a Korean language academy, there was no way they could understand me.

But killing intent was another matter.

Killing intent, honed through countless battles and brushes with death, awakened a primal fear.

Even a person with exceptional nerve could wet themselves from it. Dogs, which were even more sensitive to such things, were no exception.

Whine. Whimper.

The Tosa mastiffs sensed my killing intent, hid their teeth, tucked their tails beneath their bellies, and flattened themselves against the ground. Their anxious eyes trembled, and they dared not look my way.

“That’s right. Good dogs.”

Slice.

The moment I cut through the iron bars with Palm Force gathered around my hand and stepped into the yard, I felt as though I had passed through a soft membrane.

Then a blaring siren rang out.

Wheeeeeeeeng!

Ding.

They had taken some precautions.

Even better.

The instant the magic activated, the lights inside the mansion blazed to life.

I sensed dozens of people moving hurriedly inside. A moment later, the steel front door burst outward as if it had exploded.

Bang!

Five men emerged first. The “tail” stood at their center.

The ordinary-looking middle-aged man’s eyes now belonged to a killer.

“You…”

His face twisted, and his eyes trembled. He had clearly recognized me.

I gave him a broad smile.

“I’m with the village youth association.”

“Jin Taekyung!”

“Nope. This is Patrick.[1497]”

“How did you find this place?”

“We have a rich Young Master in our Guild. Whatever else you say about him, he knows how to get things done.”

Im Yeongjun’s sharp gaze swept our surroundings.

“Don’t tell me you came alone.”

“What if I did?”

“Looks like you did.”

His mouth twisted.

[1497]Patrick Star, called Ddung-i in the Korean dub of *SpongeBob SquarePants*, is known for answering, “No, this is Patrick.”

“Fucking idiot. There’s a limit to how ignorant you can be of the way the world works.”

“That’s what I wanted to say to you. You should’ve chosen your target more carefully.”

“That D-rank nobody who barely qualifies as a Hunter? Did they reattach his arm?”

“They did, but… Apparently, he has some lingering aftereffects. So I came to collect a little compensation.”

“I was going to kill him, but I held back. Be grateful that it ended there. If you don’t want to suffer something worse, lie flat and quiet as a dead mouse.”

“I’ve already seen something worse, and lying flat like a dead mouse isn’t my style. I’m not particularly grateful, either, so isn’t that why I came here?”

Im Yeongjun gave a short laugh.

“Kid, I know you’re excited because everyone around you treats you like a big shot, but don’t make the mistake of thinking we’re ordinary Hunters.”

Just as he said, the aura and killing intent emanating from the Black Hunters were far denser and stronger than those of ordinary Hunters.

I swept my gaze over the mansion.

I could feel them—the presences hiding inside, waiting for orders.

“One, five, ten… Twenty-eight in all. You’ve gathered quite a crowd.”

“…How?”

“I’m not an ordinary Hunter, either.”

Watching his face stiffen, I continued.

“Three. Hand over the three who took part in the attack two days ago, including you. The rest of you, disarm yourselves and tell me everything you know. Then I’ll spare your lives.”

“You crazy bastard.”

“Good. I was worried you might accept.”

That was my first and last offer.

There wouldn’t be another.

Open Inventory. Equip White Flame.

The moment the cool spear shaft filled my grasp, Im Yeongjun shouted, his voice rising almost to a scream.

“Kill him!”

That was the signal.

Dozens of Black Hunters who had been waiting in breathless silence smashed through the walls and windows and surged toward me.

Crash! Shhhhk!

A rain of countless blades and arrowheads poured in from every direction.

My eyes had already gone cold as I watched them.
“You picked the wrong person to mess with.”
Fwoooosh!

Chapter 277

An endless rain of blades and arrowheads poured in from every direction.

I didn't need to think about how to move. A picture formed naturally in my mind, and my hands moved at the same time as my thoughts.

Fwoosh!

Blue flames wrapped around the spearhead and traced a semicircle.

KRAAASH!

The arrows and weapons caught in its path split apart like tofu.

Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron was hard and sharp enough to destroy Body-Protecting Qi on its own. With Spear Energy added to it, the result was only natural.

Though perhaps not to them.

"Gasp!"

The closest Black Hunter gasped as he stared at his sword, melted by the fiery qi of the Fire Gate Divine Technique.

He was my first target.

Crack!

My grip could crush stone and rebar. When I tightened my fingers around his forearm, his flesh was mangled and bone burst through.

"Gyaaaaaah!"

I had memorized the descriptions of every man who had attacked Im Kkeokjeong. I stared intently at the Black Hunter's face as he screamed in agony.

"You're not one of them."

"Die!"

With a venomous shout, he drove a dagger up beneath my chin. Even in that much pain, his hand didn't hesitate.

This wasn't how someone moved in a raid.

These were the movements of a skilled killer.

And I tried to reason with people like these.

Once again, I reflected on what a fucking idiot I'd been.

I let out a hollow laugh and dodged the dagger. At the same time, I seized his other arm and pulled with all my strength.

No, I tore it off.

Crack-crack-crack!

"Urrrrgh…!"

His mouth gaped wide, but the pain was too great for him to scream.

I kicked him in the back as his whole body convulsed. He gasped raggedly, barely clinging to life, while blood gushed from the torn stumps.

I tossed both arms onto the lawn.

“One down.”

“…!”

“…!”

A heavy silence descended over the yard.

The Black Hunters faltered after seeing a comrade on their level taken apart in an instant. Behind them, Im Yeongjun’s eyebrows twitched as he watched.

“So you had something to rely on.”

“Yeah. That’s why I came. You don’t seem to have anything, though.”

“You fucking bastard, Jin Taekyung…”

“You should’ve listened while I was asking nicely. Because of you and the other two, this bastard can’t even jerk off by himself anymore.”

My voice remained flat as I swept my gaze around. Wherever my eyes passed, anger and confusion churned across their faces.

Sensing the shift in the atmosphere, Im Yeongjun glared and roared.

“What are you waiting for, you bastards?! I’ll save every last one of you even if I have to bathe you in potions! Don’t be afraid—beat him to death!”

I blinked. For a moment, I wondered if I had heard him correctly.

Ah, right. Potions.

“If you lose an arm or a leg, you’d need at least a high-grade potion. You guys must be loaded.”

“If that’s what it costs to remove one major obstacle, it’s worth every penny. We should’ve eliminated you from the start… I never liked the order we were given.”

“Should you really be blabbing about having someone powerful behind you? Aren’t you worried they’ll kill you to silence you?”

“Kill me to silence me?”

A sneer spread across Im Yeongjun’s lips.

“We’re the ones who silence witnesses. Besides, you’re going to die here anyway.”

“Sure, let’s put that aside for now. There’s something I’ve been wondering.”

I asked with complete sincerity.

“Those potions of yours—can they bring the dead back to life? Or do you carry three or four spare lives around?”

“What?”

Slice!

The spear answered for him. The Black Hunter groaning at my feet lost his head.

I gave the severed head a light kick, sending it rolling toward the others.

“Go on. Save him.”

“…!”

“Oh, right. Even potions can’t save you if your heart bursts or your head comes off.”

Shhk!

Without hesitation, I flicked my hand.

Two daggers shot out with terrifying speed, becoming flashes of light.

Thwack!

Two Black Hunters staggered, then collapsed.

Their bodies had been unable to withstand the internal energy carried by the daggers. Half of each man’s head was gone.

“Ah. I was trying to plant them neatly between the eyebrows, but I couldn’t control my strength.”

“…!”

The air around us seemed to vibrate.

The sneer had vanished from Im Yeongjun’s lips. A tempest now raged in the eyes of the remaining twenty-five Black Hunters.

“H-How…?”

“What the fuck…?”

Suppressed groans rose from here and there. It was something they had never experienced before.

Hunters hunted monsters.

Black Hunters had been created to hunt those Hunters.

Murder, kidnapping, blackmail, and every other filthy job—they had served as enforcers for a major Guild.

But they had clearly never imagined that they might be hunted themselves.

Much less that it would be this one-sided.

I spat phlegm onto the headless corpse.

“You bastards are like dark-path knife fighters.”

No. In terms of their mindset, dark-path knife fighters were actually better.

At least those men accepted that they might someday be stabbed to death in a back alley.

“What… exactly are you?”

His voice was bone-dry, reflecting the turmoil inside him.

I grinned at Im Yeongjun as he stared at me.

“You already know. Why bother asking?”

His gaze turned cold.

“You fooled everyone completely. That’s not the skill of a man who’s only killed once or twice.”

“Killing beasts doesn’t count as murder. Usually, it’s called slaughter.”

Step. Step.

Every time I advanced slowly, the Black Hunters surrounding me in a semicircle took a step backward.

Even the dullest among them must have realized by now that I wasn’t merely an A-rank Hunter.

They could feel the qualitatively different killing intent and the thick scent of blood clinging to me.

“Jin Taekyung.”

Im Yeongjun spoke, his face rigid.

“Taking out that D-rank Hunter was a warning. The order came from above.”

“I didn’t like the way you delivered that warning. Not one bit.”

“I understand your position. Stop here.”

“And if I don’t?”

“The next warning could be worse.”

“Worse?”

“Aren’t you worried about your mother and younger sibling?”

“…!”

The words caught in my throat.

My slow but steady advance came to an abrupt stop, and strength returned to Im Yeongjun’s voice.

“I can negotiate with the people above us. I’ll act as the stepping stone between you.”

“A stepping stone…”

“You only have to give up one thing. Stop living as A-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung and live as the civilian Jin Taekyung instead. Of course, you’ll be generously compensated.”

I gazed into Im Yeongjun’s eyes.

They held wariness toward me, but they were also the eyes of a wolf constantly searching for an opening.

After a brief silence, a dry voice escaped my lips.

“A stepping stone. That sounds good.”

The corners of Im Yeongjun’s mouth began to rise slightly. I continued smoothly.

“Since you’re a stepping stone, I can just step lightly on you and pass over. I’ll find out who’s on the other side of the stream when I get there.”

“…!”

There would be no compromise.

They had crossed the line. They were already my enemies.

The modern way and the way of Murim. I had weighed the two against each other and agonized over the choice until the very end…

But today, I would choose the latter.

“And listen, asshole. When you make an offer like that, try doing it with a more trustworthy look in your eyes.”

“Jin Taekyung!”

I heard his shout as I kicked off the ground.

The Black Hunters charged at me with gritted teeth, and I brought my spear down upon them.

Slice!

Boom!

A single punch infused with three-tenths of my internal energy.

The enhancement magic shattered, and the Tower Shield broke apart.

The tank hiding behind it stared at me in shock.

Thrust!

White Flame’s spearhead pierced his chest and burst out through his back.

The mage behind the sturdy shield hurriedly stepped backward.

Thwack!

I flicked my hand, and a dagger buried itself in the back of his head.

But it wasn’t over yet.

“Die!”

Shhhhhk!

Neck, chest, shoulder.

Three blades hurtled toward me with a fierce rush of air. Faint Sword Energy shimmered along their edges, marking their wielders as A-rank Hunters.

Slice!

I pulled the spear from the dead tank’s chest and swung it.

The three swords shattered beneath that lightning-fast strike, and one of the men collapsed clutching his throat.

Blood sprayed over me like a fountain. I released my spear and thrust both palms toward the other two men as they tried to cut me down with their broken swords.

Crack—BOOM!

Compressed air exploded outward.

The Flame Divine Palm struck them squarely in the chest, and they sank to their knees as blood poured from all seven orifices.[1498]

Their melted magical armor clung to their upper bodies and burned into their flesh, but they were dead before they could feel the pain.

"Goodbye."

I had just wiped the blood from my face with my sleeve when—

Shhk! Shhhhhk!

I tilted my head slightly.

An iron arrow thick and heavy enough to pass for a small spear flew past me and buried itself in the stone wall behind me.

Boom!

A cloud of dirt erupted as the arrow drove deep into the solid rock.

Its power was tremendous.

They've been getting on my nerves for a while.

Like ordinary Hunters, these men had a balanced distribution of roles.

They had tanks, mages, and melee damage dealers. Naturally, they also had ranged damage dealers.

Three archers had remained inside the mansion from the beginning, loosing arrow after arrow from the second-floor windows.

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

I clicked my tongue and was about to knock the arrows aside with my spear shaft when the air rippled.

A black silhouette burst from empty space and brought a dagger down to cleave my skull.

Shrrrkk!

Fast and precise.

He was clearly a melee damage dealer with an exceptional stealth-type Skill.

How many people had he killed this way?

I didn't know, but one thing was certain.

Today, he picked the wrong target.

Bang-bang-bang!

I twisted the spearhead with a deft motion.

The iron arrows, which should have been swept aside like fallen leaves, changed course and pierced the Black Hunter who had been trying to bury a dagger in my crown.

Thwack-thwack-thwack!

"Urgh!"

[1498] The seven orifices are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

Struck by arrows out of nowhere in midair, the Black Hunter fell with a heavy thud.

I pulled an iron arrow from his upper body. His body convulsed, then went still. At the same moment, I hurled the arrow back in the direction it had come from.

Shhhhhk! Thwack!

The iron arrow infused with internal energy did its job perfectly.

It flew back toward its original owners twice as fast and with twice the force it had carried when first fired.

The three archers, who had been nocking their next arrows, died almost simultaneously.

“This is fucking insane…”

The men who had been about to charge stopped in their tracks. Their hands trembled around their weapons.

They had just watched more than ten of their comrades die in the blink of an eye.

But I had no intention of stopping there.

Shrrrkk! Slice!

I charged straight into them, cutting, stabbing, and smashing.

A mist of blood formed, and someone’s arms, legs, or head flew in every direction.

“Gyaaaaaah!”

“Argh!”

Screams erupted all around me.

From among the terrified enemies, a knuckle wrapped in Fist Energy shot out and slammed into my spear shaft.

Boom!

“Retreat into the mansion!”

I let out a short laugh at Im Yeongjun’s shout. He had bought them a brief moment.

“Did you set up some magic circles as traps?”

“Shut up!”

Whoosh!

He was their leader for a reason. As expected, he was the best of them.

No, at this level, he could even be called a Peak master in Murim.

He knows how to use qi.

One reason Hunters seemed so inferior to martial artists was the way they handled qi.

But Im Yeongjun and the other Black Hunters moved far more efficiently than ordinary Hunters.

Even so, this is as far as they go.

No matter how high someone flew or how low they crawled, there were walls they could never cross.

I drove my fist toward the knuckle.

Refusing to back down, Im Yeongjun gritted his teeth and met my punch head-on.

Boom!

One Strike.

The knuckle shattered.

Boom!

Two Strike.

Im Yeongjun's fist was crushed.

KRA-BOOM!

Three Strike.

The first move of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist slammed into his shoulder.

His flesh melted, and his bones were pulverized.

It was as though a fire dragon had devoured his entire shoulder.

Im Yeongjun spat blood and flew backward.

"Team Leader!"

But he still had subordinates left.

The Black Hunters who had waited until the last moment quickly hoisted Im Yeongjun onto their backs and rushed into the mansion.

Thud!

The door had barely closed when layer upon layer of transparent barriers wrapped around the mansion.

A defensive spell?

It had to be an extremely powerful one. It felt even sturdier than the defensive magic Butler Kim had once shown me.

But I didn't stop walking.

One step carried me to the door. I punched the dozens of defensive barriers.

Four Strike.

The Heaven-Destroying Divine Fist, unleashed with all my strength, hammered into them.

Just as it had shattered an unnamed cliff on Mount Song, the Heaven-Destroying Divine Fist broke and crushed everything blocking its path.

KRAAAAAASH!

With a roar like the sky splitting apart, the defensive barriers were torn to shreds.

The roof flew off, and the walls turned to ash.

Beyond the melted front door, I saw the enemies frozen in place.

Im Yeongjun stood at their center.

His jaw trembled. A single word, sounding almost like a groan, escaped between his lips soaked in blood.

“What… what the hell are you?”

I gladly answered him.

“A monster. Same as you.”

Team Leader Choi had said it before.

This world was teeming with monsters.

So I had decided that, every once in a while, I would become a monster myself.

Just like today.

“Have you ever heard of Tendon-Splitting and Bone-Twisting?”

It didn’t take long for Im Yeongjun to open his mouth.

Chapter 278

The beautiful two-story house had been transformed into a haunted ruin.

If the dozens of layers of defensive barriers hadn't absorbed part of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist's impact, the entire place would have been reduced to ash.

Just then, I sensed someone approaching from behind, and a quiet voice sounded in my ear.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

I had been sitting on a half-charred sofa. Turning my head, I answered,

"Yes."

Team Leader Choi, Butler Kim, and Song Song stood behind me.

Their expressions were complicated as they looked at me. Considering they had seen the bodies strewn miserably across the garden, it was only natural.

Being drenched from head to toe in blood probably didn't help my appearance, either.

Song Song cautiously asked, "Did you… kill all of them?"

"Yeah."

"…!"

"I'm kidding. I spared the ones who surrendered."

Then I added gently, "For now."

The answer was for Song Song, but the warning was meant for Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim.

Team Leader Choi asked with concern, "Are you hurt anywhere?"

"As you can see, I'm fine."

"What about the survivors?"

"I gathered them in one place."

"Without taking any other measures?"

"Of course I did. For the next few hours, they'll be no different from corpses that can still breathe, so don't worry."

The personal measure I had taken was a Pressure-Point Strike.

After striking their Mute Acupoints, Paralysis Acupoints, and Sleep Acupoints, I had stacked the Black Hunters neatly inside the only room left standing.

I had used force to subdue them, but I wasn't some blood-crazed murderer who intended to kill even those who surrendered.

More importantly, they might prove useful later.

"You did well. But…"

Team Leader Choi's gaze shifted to the man sprawled at my feet.

"Who is that?"

"The owner of this house."

I rolled him over with my foot, revealing a man in his forties.

Im Yeongjun, the homeowner and leader of the Black Hunters.

His entire body was so drenched in blood that he could easily have been mistaken for a corpse, but he was very much alive. In fact, there wasn't a single wound left on him.

Butler Kim examined him and muttered knowingly, "You used potions. Several times, at that."

"Yes."

"Did you torture him?"

"You have sharp eyes."

"It was common during the Great Cataclysm. There were plenty of people worse than Black Hunters."

Song Song's expression darkened at the word *torture*. But after a faint sigh, she placed a hand on my shoulder.

"That couldn't have been easy."

It was only natural for her to be repulsed. Even I, accustomed as I was to the ways of Murim, didn't feel comfortable about what I had done.

But Im Yeongjun had been far more tight-lipped than I had expected. Ordinary threats would never have made him talk.

"These aren't ordinary opponents. Someone had to do it," Team Leader Choi said.

"If you hadn't, Hunter Jin Taekyung, I would have," Butler Kim added. "Don't take it too much to heart."

They were right. Someone had to do it. My hands were already stained with blood, so there was no reason to balk at torture now.

I shook my head to clear away my troubled thoughts, then opened my mouth.

"There's no physical evidence. Apparently, they deleted all the relevant information the moment I broke in and the alarm magic went off."

"All of it?"

"Yes. There weren't even any computers in the house. Only two people, including Im Yeongjun, had cell phones. Even those were burner phones with no identifiable source."

I showed them the remains of the cell phone I had collected beforehand.

Even someone as hopeless with technology as me could tell that recovering anything from it would be impossible. Every component had been crushed, and they had burned the SD card.

Team Leader Choi clicked his tongue when he saw the wreckage.

“Thorough. At this point, there’s no way any documents would have been left behind.”

“They didn’t.”

“What about the other Black Hunters?”

“Ten survived, but none of them knows anything. I killed the one who was effectively their deputy. Im Yeongjun personally recruited and trained everyone here.”

From what I had gathered, they operated as a thoroughly compartmentalized organization.

Everything involving the Black Hunters—from laundering their identities to paying them—had gone through Im Yeongjun.

“It’s fortunate that Im Yeongjun survived, at least. What did he tell you?”

“That…”

I suddenly stopped speaking.

The one sentence he had screamed like a howl after experiencing Tendon-Splitting and Bone-Twisting three times still echoed in my ears.

“M-Myeongdong Guild! I said Myeongdong Guild!”

A major Guild that might not rank among the country’s top ten, but easily placed within the top twenty.

And…

Jihoon.

It was also the Guild where an old friend I had met again recently belonged.

After some thought, I spoke again.

“Could you give me a little time?”

“…?”

“There’s something I need to check personally.”

Team Leader Choi studied me for a moment, then nodded.

“We’ll start cleaning up the scene. Look into it and let us know.”

“I will.”

“Let’s get started right away.”

At Team Leader Choi’s words, Butler Kim swung the staff he had been using like a cane.

The tightly shut door opened. The ten Black Hunters whose acupoints I had struck floated into the air and filed out of the house one after another.

Im Yeongjun was among them, of course.

“Everyone, stand back.”

After delivering the warning in a low voice, Butler Kim began chanting.

Mana surged. Enormous flames engulfed the two-story house, which had barely managed to retain its shape.

The fire swept through the garden and would not stop until it had erased everything.

Fwoooosh!

A cloud of acrid smoke billowed up with the flames.

Yet the quiet rural village surrounding the mansion remained peaceful.

With magic blocking all sight and sound, the mansion wouldn't be discovered until much later.

"Will this be enough?"

"More than enough. Even if we left it alone, they would step in and erase every trace of this place themselves."

People had vanished overnight, and a house had burned down. But that was all.

The villagers would talk about it for a while, but nothing would come of it.

That was how monsters with power and authority operated.

There was only one thing I wanted to know.

Garam Middle School Classmate Park Jihoon

Which side did the owner of the number saved in my phone actually belong to?

The darkness had yet to lift when Park Jihoon dressed and left his house at dawn.

A uniformed chauffeur was waiting for him at the entrance with a limousine.

"You're here, sir."

"What's going on? Why am I being picked up out of the blue at this hour?"

"I'm afraid I don't know. The Guild Master only instructed me to collect you from your home."

Fair enough. What would a mere driver know?

Clicking his tongue softly, Park Jihoon climbed into the car. Perhaps because of the early hour, the roads were deserted.

Some time later, the limousine glided to a stop in a part of Hannam-dong lined with luxury apartments and villas.

Before them stood a massive mansion.

One of the guards stationed along the stone wall ran over and bowed to Park Jihoon.

"He's waiting inside."

Park Jihoon passed through iron gates reminiscent of a European nobleman's estate and crossed a garden larger than an athletic field before finally meeting the man who had summoned him.

"Have you eaten breakfast?"

The man was in his fifties, with hair that had gone half gray. His age belied his imposing physique, and well-developed chest muscles showed beneath his white robe.

Park Jihoon bowed his head.

"Not yet."

"Then come eat. The beef-and-radish soup turned out especially well today."

It was barely six in the morning. No one would welcome breakfast this early, especially after being dragged out of bed.

Nevertheless, Park Jihoon thanked him and picked up his spoon without complaint.

"Aren't you eating, Guild Master?"

"I've already eaten. Don't mind me. Finish your meal."

The man casually unfolded a copy of that morning's newspaper.

The front page featured a photograph of a middle-aged man in a suit bowing his head solemnly.

Park Tae Seop, Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild, visits the wake of the late Hunter Jung Hyunwoo. "My heart is filled with grief. I bow my head and apologize to the bereaved family."

Only then did Park Jihoon understand why he had been summoned.

The old geezer's pissed.

The man, identical to the one in the color photograph, asked without looking up from the newspaper, "How's the picture? Did I come out well?"

"Yes. You're naturally handsome."

"That's your problem. No matter what you say, it always sounds like empty flattery."

"I mean it."

At the unhesitating answer, the middle-aged man—Park Tae Seop, Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild—raised his eyebrows.

It was a sign that his patience had run out.

"Jung Hyunwoo. Why did you kill him?"

Here it comes.

Park Jihoon quietly set down his spoon.

"I caught a whiff."

"Then you should have stopped at covering your nose."

"That was Myeongdong Guild's job. Mine is to wring the necks of anyone who catches the stink before they can go blabbing about it."

"Without my permission?"

"Do I need permission, too?"

Bang!

Park Tae Seop slammed his fist into the dining table. The table shattered with a splintering crack, sending glass and food flying in every direction.

“Guild Master!”

The guards who came rushing in were met by a furious roar.

“Get the hell out, all of you! Don’t take another step inside until I give the order!”

“…!”

They froze for a moment, then bowed and withdrew.

Park Jihoon calmly pulled out a handkerchief and wiped the soup splashed across his face.

“What a shame. It was delicious.”

“You insolent brat, still stinking of your mother’s milk…”

“We both reek of something rotten anyway. A little milk on top won’t make any difference.”

“I built this Guild with my own blood! And a little shit like you kills one of my Guild members without even telling me?”

“Come now, Guild Master.”

Park Jihoon’s smooth, unlined brow furrowed.

The handkerchief in his hand dropped onto the shattered remains of the table.

“What else was I supposed to do?”

“What did you say?”

“Don’t you know how troublesome it gets when people who catch the stink start talking? One spark, and the whole house burns down. If it were only your house at risk, I wouldn’t have said a word. But the fire would spread to our side, so I stepped in.”

“Even so, you—!”

“And I’d appreciate it if you got one thing straight. You’re a war hero who fought and bled during the Great Cataclysm? I’ll give you that. But claiming that Myeongdong Guild belongs to you is a bit…”

Park Jihoon let out a short laugh and rose from his seat.

“Thank you for breakfast. Though I barely managed a few spoonfuls.”

Park Tae Seop trembled as he watched him.

“Sit down.”

“If you have anything else to say, call me. If you keep this up, I’m going to lose my respect for a great senior like you.”

“I said sit down.”

The air around them churned violently.

Park Tae Seop, Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild, was a hero forged by the Great Cataclysm and one of the country’s highest-ranking rankers.

But Park Jihoon knew the man couldn’t lay a hand on him.

“I’ll see you next time.”

He bowed politely and was about to turn away when Park Tae Seop spoke again.

“The sparks you scattered are about to burn the whole house down. You didn’t know that?”

“What are you talking about? I handled Team Leader Jung’s matter thoroughly enough to prevent any loose talk.”

“The Black Hunters. I heard they recently went after a D-rank Hunter from the Peace Guild.”

Park Jihoon’s face stiffened.

He instinctively realized that something had gone seriously wrong.

“…What is it? What happened?”

At that moment, the phone inside Park Jihoon’s coat pocket began to vibrate.

As though possessed, he pulled it out and stared at the name filling the screen, his eyes darkening.

Jin Taekyung

Chapter 279

Jin Taekyung.

The three-syllable name stood out clearly on the screen.

Park Jihoon was about to press the call icon without thinking when a thunderous shout stopped him.

“I’m not finished talking. Put that damn phone away and sit down right now!”

“…”

“Are you deaf?”

“…No, sir. Go ahead.”

Park Jihoon turned off the screen and dropped heavily into a chair. Park Tae Seop glared at him with blazing eyes.

“Was killing a Team Leader-level Hunter without permission not enough for you?”

“I was under the impression that matter had already been discussed. ‘That person’ said they had personally contacted you to ask for your understanding.”

“Understanding? You mean threaten me?”

“They’d be hurt if they heard you say that.”

“What the hell do you have against Jin Taekyung and the Peace Guild that you’d go so far as to send Black Hunters…?”

“That’s enough.”

Park Jihoon cut him off, his voice hard.

“There’s no need for you to know things you’re better off not knowing.”

“…!”

“Isn’t it important that the Guild Master accepted the proposal? One way or another, the result matters more than the process.”

“Yeah. So is that why you turned that important result into this mess?”

Park Jihoon frowned. Park Tae Seop’s complaints were nothing new, but this was the first time he had been so openly hostile.

What the hell happened?

“That’s enough bickering. What went wrong?”

Park Tae Seop, breathing hard with anger, tossed out a single sentence.

“Two hours ago, Team 11 sent an emergency message.”

To the outside world, Myeongdong Guild had ten teams.

But that was merely its *public* face. Team 11, the team Park Tae Seop had mentioned, did not officially exist. It was made up entirely of Black Hunters.

“Did you say an emergency message?”

“If you have eyes, see for yourself.”

Park Tae Seop pulled something from his robe pocket and tossed it over. Park Jihoon caught an old-fashioned cell phone so outdated that he couldn't even guess when it had been made.

The call history had been wiped clean. The inbox held only a single text message, received two hours earlier.

> Intruder detected.

One short line.

But its contents were anything but ordinary.

Park Jihoon closed the phone and asked, "Where was it?"

"Far away. A backwater hole beside some nameless mountain. It's outside the safe zone, and there aren't any Gates nearby, so no one has any reason to go there."

"Any word after that?"

"If there had been, would I be bringing this up?"

"So they're out of contact."

"I sent people to check, but… I have a bad feeling about this."

Park Jihoon felt the same.

Seven years ago, as soon as he had been assigned to Myeongdong Guild, his first task had involved Team 11.

Park Tae Seop, the Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild, had strongly objected to hiding and training criminals. But he had been unable to defy the orders of *that person*.

That was how they had gathered roughly thirty Black Hunters.

Three A-rank Hunters. And twenty-five B-rank Hunters.

They were a force powerful enough to rival—or even surpass—Team 1, Myeongdong Guild's elite.

And now they had lost contact after an intruder appeared.

Just as unease began creeping through Park Jihoon's chest—

Brrrrr.

The phone in his inner coat pocket began to vibrate again. The longer it continued, the more his unease grew.

Ring. Ring…

The call went unanswered and ended in voicemail, just like every time before.

This was already my tenth call. I'd sent him a text ages ago, too, but he hadn't replied.

He should be at work by now.

The entrance of the high-rise building towering over the heart of Seoul was crowded with people. I was watching them absently when someone spoke to me.

“Excuse me.”

The man addressing me was dressed in a suit.

His face was angular, and his eyes were sharp. I could sense the solid build beneath his clothes and the energy coiled inside him. The man beside him, apparently his colleague, was much the same.

I put away my phone and answered,

“Yes, excuse me.”

The suited man hesitated, then opened his mouth. The name tag on his chest clearly displayed both his name and his affiliation: Myeongdong Guild.

“We’re from the Security Team. We received a report about you.”

“I’m not a sir. What kind of report?”

“We checked the CCTV footage and saw you loitering in front of our building for quite a while… Is there something you need?”

Their eyes were full of suspicion and wariness.

I was wearing track pants and a hoodie, with a cap pulled low over my face and sunglasses on top of that. A guy dressed like this peering into the building was bound to attract a report.

“Sir, would you mind moving somewhere else for a moment?”

“No, I’d rather not. And I told you, I’m not a sir.”

“It’ll only take a moment.”

Despite his fairly polite tone, his actions were anything but.

Whoosh!

With a short rush of wind, both men reached for me at the same time.

In the next instant, question marks appeared on their once-confident faces.

Tap. Grab.

“Huh?”

“What?”

I casually caught both their wrists and put on a stern expression.

“Y-You rude punks. How dare you lay hands on your teacher?”

“W-Wait a second.”

“Who the hell are you? Let go!”

The two C-rank Hunters from the Security Team were visibly flustered. No matter how hard they strained, they couldn’t move an inch, and their mouths fell open.

Should I break them?

I considered it for a moment, but the time wasn't right yet. I released their wrists before the commotion could grow any larger.

"Let's not go around putting our hands on people."

Rubbing their reddened wrists, the two men cautiously asked, "Were you… a Hunter?"

"Excuse me, but could we have your name and affiliation?"

"I'm Jin Taekyung of the Peace Guild."

"What?"

"Could you be the Lord Fuck I've heard about?"

"…You must have seen that internet broadcast."

I'd rather be the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. What the hell is Lord Fuck supposed to mean?

I sighed and lowered my sunglasses slightly. The two men gasped and immediately bowed deeply.

"It's an honor to meet you."

"You're much more handsome in person."

Their eyes sparkled like high school students who had just spotted their favorite idol. Judging by their reaction, they clearly knew nothing about what was really going on.

Of course. Anything involving the Black Hunters would be top secret. If an ordinary Security Team Hunter knew about it, the secret would have leaked long ago.

"But what brings you to our Guild…?"

"I came to see someone I know."

"Someone you know?"

I pulled a thin piece of paper from my wallet and held it out. It was Park Jihoon's business card, which I'd received a while back and kept.

"Hunter Park Jihoon of Team 1?"

The Security Team Hunter tilted his head at the card, then turned to his colleague.

"Senior, do you know who this is?"

"Who?"

"He's supposedly Hunter Park Jihoon from Team 1. I know all the Team 1 Hunters, but I can't quite place him…"

"Park Jihoon, Park Jihoon… Oh, him. You know. That guy."

He elbowed his colleague in the side, and only then did the other man let out an "Oh!"

The two of them looked back and forth between me and the business card with fascinated expressions.

What's with that reaction?

My eyes narrowed. Unable to see my expression behind my sunglasses, the Security Team Hunter asked, “Are you close with Hunter Park Jihoon?”

“We went to middle school together.”

“Ohhh, so you’re friends.”

I gave him a gentle smile.

“Well, for now.”

“Huh?”

“I’m joking.”

Maybe.

Oblivious to my thoughts, the Security Team Hunters laughed and kept asking questions.

“So you came to see Hunter Park Jihoon?”

“Yes. He wasn’t answering his phone, and he wasn’t at home, either. I thought I might find him at work.”

“We’re sorry. We had no idea.”

“You were just doing your job, so don’t worry about it. More importantly, is Jihoon inside?”

The senior Security Team Hunter answered, “He probably won’t come in today, either.”

“Today, too?”

“Yes. He hardly ever comes to work. Maybe once a month? I’ve been here almost a year and have only seen him a few times. This guy’s barely been here a month, so…”

“Sounds like Myeongdong Guild’s Hunters don’t come to work very often.”

“Of course they do. I don’t know why, but everyone just accepts that he doesn’t.”

Yeah. Why is that?

I’d never heard of a Guild Hunter who showed up for work once a month.

The question that had taken root in one corner of my mind grew deeper.

Without letting it show, I said, “Could you try contacting Jihoon for me? I understand there’s a separate phone for Guild summons.”

“Uh, that’s…”

The two men hesitated, so I made them an offer they couldn’t refuse.

“I came to discuss a cooperative raid. If I put in a word, I think I could get another person or two added…”

“Whoa.”

“Are you serious?”

Of course not.

It was all a lie from beginning to end. But I kept a perfectly straight face and continued.

“You’re both C-rank, right?”

“Yes, sir.”

“How did you know?”

“I can tell at a glance. But you two seem too good to waste away in the Security Team.”

Strictly speaking, a Guild’s Security Team was little more than a backwater department.

If a Hunter were truly skilled, why would the Guild waste him on guard duty? From the Guild’s perspective, sending him on raids would be far more profitable.

There was no way the two Security Team Hunters didn’t know that. Their eyes lit up.

“I’ll contact him right away!”

“I’d appreciate that.”

“Is there anything else you need?”

“Would it be all right if I looked around the Guild for a bit? I can wait for Jihoon inside.”

“Yes. Yes, of course.”

Unlike the senior, who was bowing obsequiously, the junior Hunter’s face had gone stiff.

He’d only joined a month ago. His sense of duty and loyalty to the company were probably still burning bright.

“Senior, I don’t think that’s right.”

“What? You little punk.”

“I really respect Hunter Jin Taekyung, too, but doesn’t this violate the Guild’s internal regulations?”

“Hey, you idiot!”

The senior seemed to realize he’d slipped up as soon as he shouted. He glanced at me, then lowered his voice to a whisper.

“Are you crazy? It’s an A-Rank Gate. You could rot in the Security Team for three years and never get another opportunity like this.”

“Then we should report it to the Team Leader first…”

“God, you’re so damn rigid. Why do we need to report that he wants to look around for a moment? It’s not like he’s just anybody. He’s Hunter Jin Taekyung.”

“No, even so…”

“Please. Try to live with a little yutori, okay?”[1499]

[1499] *Yutori* is a Korean colloquialism borrowed from Japanese, meaning leeway or flexibility. Cheol Soo objects to the Japanese-derived word.

"Yutori?"[1500]

The junior Hunter's expression suddenly turned grave.

"In the current climate, please refrain from carelessly using words like that. It makes me uncomfortable."

"You're out of your mind. Do you want your life at the Guild to get uncomfortable?"

What a complete circus.

Clicking my tongue, I stepped forward. The junior Hunter flinched, then thrust out his chest.

"D-Do you have something to say?"

"No. I was just moved by what I heard."

"What?"

"You're a true patriot, and your loyalty to the company goes without saying. I'll be sure to mention it when I meet the Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild later."

"T-The Guild Master?"

"Yes. Jihoon said he'd speak to the Guild Master, too. I should make sure to mention that there's an excellent talent here."

I glanced at the name tag on the junior Hunter's chest and added, "Hunter Kim Cheol Soo."

"…!"

The eyes of Kim Cheol Soo, devoted company man, trembled with emotion.

With my most amiable smile, I asked, "Can I go in now?"

Kim Cheol Soo shouted at the top of his lungs, "Irasshaimase!"[1501]

"…Ah, yes. Arigato."[1502]

The luxurious twenty-story building belonged to Myeongdong Guild.

The senior Hunter had pulled rank to ditch his junior and come with me. He chattered away as we walked.

"The first through ninth floors house the civilian departments—tax, accounting, corporate affairs, and so on. From the tenth through the nineteenth floors, each floor belongs to a raid team."

"What about the twentieth?"

"The Guild Master and the board of directors, obviously."

"I see."

[1500] *Yutori* is a Korean colloquialism borrowed from Japanese, meaning leeway or flexibility. Cheol Soo objects to the Japanese-derived word.

[1501] *Irasshaimase* is a Japanese greeting called out by shop staff to welcome customers.

[1502] *Arigato* is Japanese for "thank you."

"Team 1 is the Guild's elite team, so they're on the nineteenth floor."

Ding.

The elevator arrived as he finished speaking. I pressed the button for the nineteenth floor and was waiting for the doors to close when—

"Hey, hey! Wait!"

The senior Hunter hurriedly pressed the open button.

The doors slid open, and a middle-aged man with a receding hairline stepped inside.

He gave us a sidelong glance, then covered the receiver with one hand as he spoke.

"Yes, yes. No, it's nothing. Just the elevator. Yes."

The energy coming from him as he continued his important call was formidable.

An A-rank Hunter?

The senior Hunter had gone rigid at the man's appearance. I gave him a questioning look, and he discreetly raised one finger while mouthing the answer.

Team 1 Leader.

No wonder he hadn't pressed a button.

As Team 1 Leader, he was naturally headed for the nineteenth floor. I listened to his call.

And in the next instant, a familiar voice pierced my ears.

"How does it make any sense that all twenty-eight of them were wiped out? Hurry up and—"

"…!"

My body trembled as if I'd been electrocuted.

That familiar voice.

And the number twenty-eight.

So it was you.

My hand moved the instant the thought struck me.

Grab!

"Ghk! Who the hell are you…?"

I clamped a hand around the Team 1 Leader's throat like a shackle and whispered into the receiver.

"Park Jihoon. You fucking bastard."

Chapter 280

“Park Jihoon, you fucking bastard.”

“…”

The voice on the other end cut off mid-sentence.

I couldn’t see him, but his confusion and agitation at that moment came through clearly enough.

“What’s the matter? If someone calls you, you should answer.”

After a moment, he replied.

“Is that you?”

“Yeah, it’s me, you bastard.”

My voice came out heated. Blood raced through my veins, and my heart hammered in my chest.

But my head was as cold as if I’d been doused with ice water.

Maybe some part of me had already seen this coming.

I kept thinking, surely not. Surely not.

But the number twenty-eight falling from his lips had been enough to turn a faint suspicion into certainty.

What I wanted to know was whose orders they were acting on—and how deeply he was involved.

“Did you send those bastards?”

A low, smooth baritone answered.

“Who knows? If that’s what happened, then I suppose I did.”

“…”

“What? Did you think I’d deny it?”

Well, look at this guy.

His attitude—as if he had nothing whatsoever to be ashamed of—drew a hollow laugh from me.

“Who told you? Im Yeongjun? Of course. He’s the only one it could’ve been. I thought he knew how to keep his mouth shut…but I misjudged him.”

Park Jihoon clicked his tongue and continued.

“Fucking idiot. I never should’ve left it to him.”

“What did the shit do wrong? The asshole who dropped his pants and started straining in public is the one to blame. But you…”

Crack.

The Team 1 Leader, still struggling with his neck trapped in my grip, turned blue.

“Did you think about how you were going to clean up after taking that dump?”

"It's unexpected that things turned out this way…but do you really think I'd have done my business without considering the cleanup?"

"Yeah. That's exactly what it looks like."

"What?"

"Can you handle me?"

Silence followed.

One second. Two. Three.

Then, at the end of that brief silence, came a cold, razor-edged voice unlike any I had ever heard from him.

"Take one more step, and both you and the Peace Guild are finished."

"So?"

"It's not too late. Don't make this any bigger. Come out. Let's end it here."

Hearing that, it suddenly occurred to me that the way the world worked wasn't so different from a fight.

The one who seized the advantage pressed forward without mercy. The one who was afraid took the first step back.

And I knew exactly what Park Jihoon feared.

Black Hunters.

The existence of the Black Hunters—the illegal private armies maintained by major Guilds.

The thought that they were holding Park Jihoon back made the corners of my mouth curl upward.

"End it?"

"Yes."

"Who says?"

"…!"

"You people started this. I'll decide where it ends."

On the other end of the phone, Park Jihoon's breathing grew ragged.

"Well, this is something. I knew you were stupid, but you're even worse than I thought."

"The result will be beyond anything you imagined, too. Please fucking look forward to it, you son of a bitch."

That was when it happened.

Ding.

"Nineteenth floor."

With the mechanical announcement, the tightly closed elevator doors slowly slid open.

A broad hallway with a high ceiling came into view. Dozens of people moved through it.

Several naturally glanced in our direction. A moment later, their mouths dropped open.

“T-Team Leader?”

“You there! Who the hell are you…?”

Instead of answering, I hurled the Team 1 Leader at them. A Hunter approaching with an accusing finger outstretched went crashing into the wall along with him.

At the same time, an employee sitting at the desk screamed and pressed the emergency button.

WEEEEEE!

“Emergency! Emergency!”

“Intruder! Team 1, arm yourselves!”

Amid the piercing alarm, Park Jihoon’s final words reached my ears.

“Go ahead, then. Let’s see you try.”

Beep. Beep. Beep…

I shoved the Team 1 Leader’s phone, now disconnected, into my inner pocket.

When my hand emerged again, it held two daggers instead.

Let’s see me try?

I’d been planning to.

“Who are you?!”

“Drop your weapons! Now, unless you want to die!”

Myeongdong Guild’s elite Hunters armed themselves with astonishing speed and surrounded me in a semicircle.

The elevator was behind me. The only other person there stood frozen like a plaster statue, muttering to himself.

“This is a dream. It has to be.”

I glanced at him, half out of his mind, and asked,

“What phone do you use?”

“Gasp!”

“Your phone. What kind?”

“I-I use an AdultPhone 25.[1503]”

“Ah. The apple you bit into and spat out.”

“Y-Yes, yes. That’s right.”

“Take it out and start recording.”

“Yes, sir!”

[1503] “AdultPhone” is a pun on iPhone: the Korean word *ai* means “child,” while *eoreun* means “adult.”

He answered at the top of his lungs, then froze halfway through pulling out his phone.

“Y-Yes, sir? I’m sorry, but what did you just say?”

“You said you have an AdultPhone 25.[1504] Its camera’s much better than mine, so I figured you should do the filming.”

“F-Film what?”

“Everything.”

Just then, the fallen Team 1 Leader sprang to his feet and roared.

“What are you waiting for, you bastards? Beat the shit out of him!”

“Team Leader, isn’t that Hunter Jin Taekyung? What is going on all of a sudden…?”

“I’ll take responsibility.”

In any Guild, Team 1 was both its symbol and its elite force.

For Myeongdong Guild, consistently ranked among Korea’s top ten, that went without saying. Its Team 1 members were consummate professionals—living combat machines.

“This is an order from above. Don’t think of him as a person. Think of him as a monster and fight.”

The moment their Team Leader gave them a firm order, dozens of gazes sank into cold focus.

Five tower shields at the front slammed into the marble floor in perfect unison.

Boom!

“Formation—!”

In the middle of their peaceful daily lives, the downtown building became a battlefield.

What am I looking at?

Lee Minsu, a C-rank Hunter assigned to Myeongdong Guild’s Security Team, blinked.

The scene unfolding before him was simply too unreal.

Krrr-crack! Boom!

A tower shield as sturdy as an armored vehicle shattered, and a massive tank flew far away as if it had been struck by a giant’s hammer.

For the briefest instant, a gap opened—barely wide enough for one person.

A pale figure slipped through it.

And then—

Shriiiik! Slash! Slash!

[1504] “AdultPhone” is a pun on iPhone: the Korean word *ai* means “child,” while *eoreun* means “adult.”

“Gaaah!”

“Gasp!”

The shield wall collapsed in a flash of light.

The tanks pitched forward in an undignified heap, the tendons in their calves cleanly severed.

How did he…?

He couldn’t even see the strikes properly.

Blink once, and two people fell. Blink twice, and three or four went down.

Every time the young man in the gray hoodie, Jin Taekyung, took a step, blood spurted and screams overflowed.

“S-Stop him!”

“Damage dealer!”

The front line where the tanks had been holding had already collapsed the moment the battle began. Five blades swung powerfully toward Jin Taekyung as he advanced one step at a time.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Both shoulders. His chest. Both legs.

Three attacks targeted his upper body, while two went for his lower body. There was no way to evade them without retreating.

“We got him!”

At the instant someone cried out in delight, the dagger in Jin Taekyung’s hand blurred like mist.

Clang-clang-clang-clang-clang!

All five blades, which everyone had been certain would connect, shot into the air.

The Hunters who had wielded them stared at Jin Taekyung in shock. The force of the deflection had torn their palms open, leaving them drenched in blood.

“W-What the…?”

“That’s impossible!”

Jin Taekyung answered their cries in a flat voice.

“Looks possible to me.”

Slash!

A single line swept horizontally through the air.

An attack that could neither be seen nor avoided.

Directly in its path stood the five Hunters who had just attacked him.

Fwoosh!

As the Hunters fell, spraying fountains of blood from their chests, a streak of light pierced between them.

Whooosh! Thunk!

The arrowhead stopped just short of Jin Taekyung's chest.

An A-rank Hunter had fired it with perfect accuracy, mana coursing through the shaft.

But what stopped it was neither a shield coated in various magics nor a sharp weapon.

Crack.

Jin Taekyung snapped the arrow shaft between two fingers and flicked his hand.

With a terrifying whistle, the arrow shot back along its original path, shattered three defensive spells, and buried itself in its owner's shoulders.

Thud!

"Ghk!"

"Fire one more arrow, and I'll make sure you end up with an odd number of balls."

"…!"

"The rest of you, back off unless you want your balls lopsided too. It's annoying having to hold back."

He had been holding back?

The Hunters of Team 1 felt as if they had been possessed by ghosts. It was hard enough to believe that he had rendered more than a dozen people unable to fight in the time it took to drink a glass of cold water.

And he had been holding back while doing it?

The same thought flashed through every mind.

What kind of monster is this?

Who were they?

They were Myeongdong Guild's elite, battle-hardened veteran Hunters. Even the least experienced had eight years under their belt, while the most senior had been Hunters for more than twenty.

They had earned their positions through skills far surpassing those of other Hunters at the same rank, and they had taken immense pride in that fact.

At least, they had—until they faced Jin Taekyung here today.

"Please move aside while I'm still speaking politely, Seniors. I'd really like to smash every one of your faces in, but you don't seem to be directly involved, so this is all I'm doing."

Loose track pants and a gray hoodie. He looked as if he had stepped out to visit the café down the street.

Yet no one dared dismiss his words.

He had already displayed his strength and seared it into their minds.

"So clear a path."

An overwhelming aura crushed the corridor, leaving even veterans of countless brutal battles inside Gates struggling to breathe.

It awakened a primal terror unlike anything they had ever felt from a monster.

Monster. That bastard is a real monster.

Step. Step.

The monster walked straight toward them.

The Hunters unconsciously moved aside to let him pass.

That was when—

"Burning Hands!"

Whoosh!

A hand wreathed in flame came crashing down on Jin Taekyung amid fierce heat.

The fire spell could melt solid rock, but the enormous hand of mana vanished without a trace the instant it struck Jin Taekyung's palm.

"M-Magic?"

"It's called the Flame Divine Palm. Pretty useful, right?"

The Team 1 Leader's eyes widened at the sight of his palm engulfed in blue flame.

Jin Taekyung stared at him and ran his tongue over his dry lips.

He looked like a predator that had just discovered prey it had forgotten about.

"Ah. You're the one exception to what I said earlier."

"Gasp."

Whoosh!

Jin Taekyung's form scattered like a ghost.

But the Team 1 Leader was an exceptional battle mage in his own right, accomplished enough to command Myeongdong Guild's elite team. Even in his panic, he reacted quickly.

"Blink!"

It was a teleportation spell that allowed him to move anywhere within ten meters,[1505] provided he could see the destination.

If I move behind him and unleash my attack spells all at once, even someone as skilled as him…

The Team 1 Leader used Blink to move behind Jin Taekyung.

For an instant, it felt as though the world had stopped.

Jin Taekyung's clear, deep-black eyes were right in front of his face.

Thud.

A palm still radiating heat pressed down on his shoulder.

"Why are you so surprised?"

"…!"

"You practically advertised where you were going with your eyes."

Had he predicted the direction from the movement of his gaze?

[1505] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

No. That wasn’t all.

The Team 1 Leader’s body trembled as though he had been struck by lightning.

His movement was faster than my Blink.

What kind of monster was he?

And what kind of monster had Park Jihoon—and Myeongdong Guild—provoked?

With a trembling voice, the Team 1 Leader recited the final spell he had prepared.

“P-Poison.”

Whoosh.

A cloud of green poisonous fog burst forth and enveloped Jin Taekyung’s face.

But just as the Team 1 Leader’s instincts had warned him, the monster proved once again that he truly was a monster.

“Ugh. Smells like a fart.”

His handsome brow furrowed.

That was his entire reaction to the Poison spell.

Having reached Peak and attained the realm of Unaffected by a Hundred Poisons, Jin Taekyung blew on the frozen Team 1 Leader.

“Hoo.”

“Gasp.”

The Team 1 Leader inhaled the poisonous fog, and his face turned blue.

Jin Taekyung grabbed him by the nape as the paralyzing poison stiffened his entire body, then looked around and asked,

“Where’s that bastard Park Jihoon’s office?”

Ssssk!

Ten fingers pointed toward a single door.

Chapter 281

The limousine sped down the road without so much as a jolt.

Park Jihoon took a bottle of water from the refrigerator and offered it to the middle-aged man sitting across from him.

“Would you like some?”

“At a time like this? And where did you learn to offer someone else’s things as if they were your own?”

“Then I suppose it’s all right if I drink only half. I have at least that much of a stake in bringing Myeongdong Guild to where it is today.”

“…”

Myeongdong Guild Master Park Tae Seop glared silently as Park Jihoon tipped back the bottle.

“You’re awfully calm.”

After drinking exactly half, Park Jihoon leaned back against the plush seat.

“Is there some reason I should be worried?”

“This whole mess has erupted, and you’re acting as though nothing’s wrong?”

“It’s nothing more than a minor incident.”

“A single drop of water can bring down a tower of sand.”

“Because it’s made of sand.”

“You’re saying Myeongdong Guild is different?”

“Five hundred Hunters under its banner. Twenty of them A-rank. At this point, it wouldn’t be wrong to call it an iron tower instead of a tower of sand. And…”

The corners of Park Jihoon’s mouth curved gently upward.

“Myeongdong Guild shouldn’t even be part of the comparison. We have ‘that person,‘ after all.”

“…That’s true.”

Park Tae Seop nodded reluctantly, though his expression remained displeased.

Park Jihoon studied him.

“What is it? What has you so anxious you can’t sit still?”

After a brief silence, Park Tae Seop spoke.

“A feeling.”

“What?”

“When you reach my age, you develop instincts you can’t explain.”

Ha.

Park Jihoon suppressed a laugh. He had wondered what the man was going to say, but in the end, it was nothing more than the grumbling of an old man past sixty.

Just a feeling? What a load of nonsense.

The thought showed plainly on his face, and Park Tae Seop had lived too long not to notice.

“You may think it’s nonsense. I understand. It’s beyond greenhorns like you.”

“Ah, I’m sorry if you took it that way.”

“And only a greenhorn could apologize in a tone without a shred of sincerity.”

“I simply don’t understand. What exactly is bothering you so much?”

After a short silence, a name slipped out.

“Jin Taekyung.”

He breathed the name like a sigh. It had haunted his thoughts ever since they lost contact with Team 11.

For a moment, he had dismissed it as lingering unease over the operation going awry.

But that wasn’t it.

His intuition, which had even endured the Great Cataclysm, had given him the answer to what troubled him.

“He’s a siege cannon. One capable of cracking not just a tower of sand, but an iron one.”

Without waiting for a reply, Park Tae Seop reached out. He picked up the bottle of water Park Jihoon had left behind and drained it in large gulps.

His throat had become unbearably dry as soon as he finished speaking.

Park Jihoon watched with a deep frown.

Has the old man gone senile?

He could admit that the operation had not gone entirely smoothly. There had been unexpected complications, particularly with the Black Hunters and Team 11.

But even taking that into account, Park Tae Seop’s reaction was far too extreme.

It was only natural that Park Jihoon, who absolutely worshiped “that person,” should feel displeased.

“I didn’t realize you held Jin Taekyung in such high regard.”

“He’s proven himself.”

“Jin Taekyung only began attracting attention recently.”

“And he’s shown us a great deal in that short time.”

“Shown us?”

A mocking smile touched Park Jihoon’s lips.

“Won Myunghoon was trash. He was at the very bottom of the rankers, and even then, they only put his name on the list once as an act of charity during all that Korean Wave[1506] hype. You know that too, Guild Master.”

[1506]The Korean Wave refers to the international popularity of South Korean entertainment and culture.

“I heard he was stupid and greedy, and that his fame made him look more skilled than he really was.”

“And the Named Monster? They called it a Named Monster, but that Black Drake was the weakest one to appear in nearly twenty years. The Magic Gem recovered from its corpse wasn’t much different from one taken from an A-rank monster.”

“Then could you kill that weak Named Monster by yourself?”

“I don’t see why not.”

Park Jihoon answered without hesitation.

He took pride in his own abilities.

His natural talent had earned him the honor of being chosen by “that person.” It was why, despite not yet being thirty, he could sit across from the Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild and look him in the eye.

But the next question made him falter.

“Then what if you fought Jin Taekyung? Are you certain you could defeat him?”

“…Of course.”

His answer came half a beat late. Realizing it, Park Jihoon pressed his lips together.

“That hesitation just now seems to say something about what kind of person Jin Taekyung is.”

Park Jihoon replied coldly, “I was merely reminded of the past.”

“Ah. You said you two were friends, didn’t you?”

“I don’t want to discuss that. My point is that this incident isn’t as serious as you think, Guild Master.”

“We don’t even know whether Team 11 is alive or dead, and the most talked-about public figure in the country has stormed Myeongdong Guild headquarters. Yet you’re saying this isn’t serious?”

“He’s an idiot. He couldn’t control his temper, so he recklessly barged into Myeongdong Guild headquarters.”

About ten minutes earlier, Park Jihoon had been speaking with the Team 1 Leader when Jin Taekyung’s voice suddenly came over the phone.

He had been startled.

And relieved.

This will make things easy.

Myeongdong Guild had more than five hundred Hunters. Even if half were away on raids, an enormous number remained at headquarters.

Among them was Team 1, the Guild’s elite force.

“Jin Taekyung walked straight into the tiger’s den. All we have to do is keep him there while we sort everything out.”

Even if reporters caught the scent of the story and swarmed in, there was nothing to fear.

He had—no, “that person” had—the power to render cameras and microphones useless.

“I’ll have everything cleaned up by the end of the day.”

Park Tae Seop’s face suddenly looked much older as he muttered, “This feels wrong. Maybe it’s my age, but I’m starting to feel the strain.”

“It’s only a passing breeze. It wouldn’t do for the legs of a man who survived the Great Cataclysm to start trembling now.”

The remark held more reproach than encouragement. Park Tae Seop recognized that and fell silent.

Just then, the dull chime of a phone notification sounded.

“That isn’t mine.”

“It’s mine.”

“Who is it?”

“Manager Kim, the man in charge of my security. I sent him to find out what happened to Team 11. It seems he’s just arrived.”

“Good. Tell him to erase every trace of Team 11 first.”

“Are you giving me orders now?”

Frowning, Park Tae Seop answered the phone.

“It’s me. What happened? Hm? Ah, I see.”

His brow furrowed, then smoothed. His pupils dilated and contracted.

As his expression grew increasingly strange, Park Tae Seop pulled the phone away from his ear.

“What happened?”

“Take it.”

Park Tae Seop thrust the phone toward him, a vein bulging on his forehead.

“What?”

“Hurry!”

Bewildered, Park Jihoon took the phone and pressed it to his ear.

A voice as soft as a cat’s paw slipped into his ear.

“Hunter Park Jihoon of Myeongdong Guild Team 1?”

Park Jihoon knew the instant he heard it.

The caller was not Manager Kim, whom he had encountered in passing several times.

The voice was young and polite, yet carried an air that discouraged familiarity.

“This is Park Jihoon. Who am I speaking to?”

Something felt wrong.

The unfamiliar voice answered the unease in his question.

“My name is Choi Minwoo.”

"Who?"

"Ah, I'm with the Peace Guild. I'm a Team Leader there."

"…The Peace Guild?"

"Yes."

Fuck.

Park Jihoon's lips twitched.

Those few words were enough for him to understand what had happened. Myeongdong Guild's people had walked straight into the Peace Guild's trap.

There was no need to see what had happened to Manager Kim, the phone's owner. He was obviously either bound tightly and unconscious or helplessly watching someone else use his phone.

Myeongdong Guild, you fucking idiots.

Team Leader Choi's voice drifted leisurely through the receiver, as relaxed as a victor's.

"I called because I'd like to have a conversation."

"Well, the thing is…"

Park Jihoon clenched his teeth, his mind racing.

Then he felt a vibration against his chest.

It had not come from Park Tae Seop's phone.

"Hunter Park Jihoon?"

"Wait. Just a moment."

With his free hand, Park Jihoon pulled his own phone from the inner pocket of his suit.

A text message had arrived. The sender was…

[Team 1 Leader]

It's done.

Relief spread across Park Jihoon's lips in a smile. Jin Taekyung, who had entered the tiger's den known as Myeongdong Guild, had finally been forced to his knees.

The scales that had tipped against him were balanced again.

But then—

"…Huh?"

The smile vanished from his lips.

Filling the six-inch screen was not a report that the Team 1 Leader had captured Jin Taekyung, but a single photograph.

What is this?

He recognized the faces.

A young man grinned broadly at the camera, blood spattered across his face. Beside him, caught firmly in his grasp, was a middle-aged man whose complexion had turned as blue as a drug addict's.

Jin Taekyung…and the Team 1 Leader?

That wasn't all.

The background was familiar too.

The nameplate reading *Hunter Park Jihoon, Myeongdong Guild Team 1* made it unmistakably clear where they were.

And there was one more thing.

No way… Did no one stop him? That one Jin Taekyung?

A reality he did not want to believe.

Park Jihoon's eyes darted helplessly around as they began to tremble.

Bzzz.

Another text arrived. Its contents were brief but devastating.

Five Korean characters were enough to shatter Park Jihoon's composure.

> **Team 1 Leader**
> └ **Team 1 Leader:** Bring Melona when you come.[1507]

"This—this fucking…!"

Crack.

The phone in Park Jihoon's hand crumpled like a sheet of paper.

Watching him, Myeongdong Guild Master Park Tae Seop muttered quietly,

"We're fucked."

> **Team Leader Choi**
> └ **Team Leader Choi:** We've captured the people dispatched by Myeongdong Guild.

The text was from Team Leader Choi.

A few hours earlier, after burning down the safe house used by the Black Hunters, we had split up.

Team Leader Choi and the others would lie in ambush to secure solid evidence, while I had insisted on acting alone.

[1507] Melona is a popular Korean melon-flavored ice cream bar.

It was because Team Leader Choi had argued that we absolutely had to capture something that could serve as evidence or a witness.

He was right.

Every Black Hunter, including Im Yeongjun, had been managed so meticulously that their identities had already been laundered clean. There wasn't even the slightest link connecting them to Myeongdong Guild.

Team Leader Choi had identified that problem exactly.

He's always calm and composed.

Looking back, he had never once lost sight of the right path.

Having Butler Kim as both an excellent mage and a wise adviser probably helped, but at this point, Choi had to be a natural.

Now we have solid leverage.

On top of the captured Black Hunters, we had official Myeongdong Guild employees in our hands.

That should make an excellent shield.

Or a dagger.

I sent him a message thanking him for his hard work, along with the photograph I'd taken earlier.

Maybe it was because it was an AdultPhone,[1508] but even a picture taken with my foot came out great.

"Maybe I should replace my phone while I'm at it."

Someone flinched at my mutter. It was the Security Team Hunter I'd hired as my personal cameraman for the day.

Of course, I wasn't paying him.

"What's wrong?"

"N-Nothing, sir!"

"Make yourself comfortable. Don't just stand there. Sit on the sofa or something."

"I'm comfortable like this!"

"You look pretty uncomfortable to me."

"I'm fiiiine!"

Was it my imagination, or was there a sob mixed into his shout?

As an ordinary Security Team Hunter, he'd just watched me beat the living shit out of Team 1, the Guild's elite—people he normally wouldn't even dare look in the eye.

His reaction was understandable.

The ones who came later weren't much different.

[1508] "AdultPhone" is a Korean pun on iPhone: *ai* can mean "child," while *eoreun* means "adult."

The other Myeongdong Guild Hunters who arrived afterward didn’t dare attack me after seeing the scene before them.

Of course, quite a few of them were armed with fierce devotion to their Guild.

Unfortunately, they didn’t have the skills to back it up. Everyone who charged me got beaten to a pulp and carried away.

After I had knocked down around fifty of them, no one else tried to attack me. Park Jihoon’s office became forbidden territory that no one could enter.

I sank into his chair.

He must be racing here like a madman by now.

Just thinking about him made my heart turn cold.

A middle-school classmate I had happened to run into on the street after ten long years.

How much of what I saw was the real Park Jihoon?

Hurry up and get here. Before I get any angrier.

Crack.

The armrest snapped beneath my grip.

“H-He’s here!”

“Guild Master!”

Murmurs spread beyond the office door like a wildfire.

At the same time, I sensed two immense presences approaching without hesitation.

He’s here.

And in the next moment, the door blew apart with a thunderous roar.

BOOM!

Chapter 282

BOOM!

Two people appeared amid the thunderous roar.

I waved at the familiar face among them.

“Well, look who’s here. You fucking bastard.”

“…You.”

I’d been planning to punch him in the mouth the moment I saw him, but the sight of his face twisting with rage drew a quiet laugh from me instead.

Eyeing Park Jihoon’s tightly clenched fist, I put on a disappointed expression.

“You didn’t bring it?”

“What?”

“Melona.”[1509]

“You little—”

A huge hand closed around his shoulder as his face flushed red.

“There are still too many eyes on us.”

Biting his lip, Park Jihoon took a step back.

I watched in amusement as the middle-aged man beside him cleared everyone from the immediate area, then addressed me.

“Do you know who I am?”

I nodded. There was no way I wouldn’t recognize that face.

His name carried plenty of weight, and he appeared often enough in newspapers, magazines, and other media.

Park Tae Seop, Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild.

A war hero who had distinguished himself during the Great Cataclysm, and one of Korea’s top rankers.

He had survived countless brutal struggles to become the master of a major Guild. To Hunters, he was both an inspiration and a respected elder.

I used to respect him too.

Not anymore.

My good memories of Park Tae Seop had expired two days ago.

What you thought tended to show in your attitude. Reading the undisguised hostility in my gaze, Park Tae Seop spoke.

“You… consider me your enemy.”

“I can’t exactly consider you a friend. We both know what’s going on.”

“Don’t be so quick to decide. Live long enough, and you’ll realize there are no eternal friends or enemies.”

[1509] Melona is a popular Korean melon-flavored ice cream bar.

“I don’t know about the part where there are no eternal enemies.”

I looked at Park Jihoon beside him.

“But the part about there being no eternal friends makes a lot of sense.”

Park Jihoon replied coldly.

“Your premise is wrong from the start. We were never friends.”

“We were never friends.”

I sank deeper into the chair and repeated his words under my breath.

One thing I still couldn’t understand was Park Jihoon’s sudden change in attitude.

But…

“Then again, what does that matter now? Whatever we had was already over the moment you sent those Black Hunters.”

At the mention of that sensitive term, Park Tae Seop waved a hand.

At the Guild Master’s command, the hundred or so Hunters filling the hallway receded like the tide.

Listening to their footsteps fade into the distance, I curled my lips.

“You’re not exactly being open about it.”

“It’s a disgrace.”

“And you’re irritatingly honest.”

“I’m personally ashamed of it.”

“For someone who considers himself ashamed, you gave a pretty damn despicable order.”

“…”

“Why?”

Discomfort flickered across Park Tae Seop’s face, but it wasn’t directed at me.

For the briefest instant, his gaze touched Park Jihoon beside him before darting away.

Well, well…

That reaction hadn’t been deliberate.

If it had slipped out unconsciously, he was definitely hiding something.

I thought back over everything that hadn’t quite added up.

Something stinks to high heaven. It reeks.

As I muttered to myself, Park Jihoon abruptly spoke.

“To keep you and the Peace Guild in check.”

“Keep us in check?”

“A new powerhouse emerging means a smaller slice of the pie for someone else. I’m sure the other Guilds feel the same way we do.”

On the surface, it made sense.

Korea's Guild market was already oversaturated. Its tiers had been divided and its pecking order established. The old powers had no desire to see a new competitor emerge.

"The Peace Guild is dangerous. For now, you're confined to Bucheon, but soon you'll grow at a frightening pace and expand your influence."

"So you sent the Black Hunters?"

"We did. But didn't I already tell you? It was only a warning."

"And I believe I already told you that your pathetic warning left someone crippled."

"Crippled? They reattached his two severed arms without any problems. His daily life won't be affected at all. Is that what people call crippled these days?"

"He might as well be. His career as a Hunter is over."

"Better his career than the entire Guild."

"What?"

Park Jihoon snorted.

"This is only the beginning. Every high-rank Gate worth entering has already been closed off to your Guild. With the surrounding Guilds shutting you out, you'll slowly wither away and die."

Something Team Leader Choi had told me a few days ago suddenly came to mind.

The other Guilds had snapped up every A-rank Gate.

Because of that, I'd been forced to drag the rookies from one C-rank or B-rank Gate to another, unable to gain any meaningful EXP.

"Don't tell me that was—"

"You're slow. Did you think it was a coincidence?"

The corners of Park Jihoon's mouth rose. He had not only fully regained his composure, but was even relaxed enough to lean back against the sofa.

"I heard you recruited a lot of Guild members recently. What are you going to do now? At this rate, you'll have to let them all go within a year. You'll be lucky if they don't sue when you can't pay their allowances."

"…"

I slowly relaxed my folded arms.

"You're good at this. No wonder you're a major Guild."

"Well, I suppose we are."

"But… we've got a pretty decent card too. I think it'd be interesting if everything Myeongdong Guild did behind the scenes after scraping together a bunch of criminal bastards came to light. What do you think?"

I continued without waiting for Park Jihoon to respond.

“Judging by how things work around here, you’d just snatch them away if we handed them over to the police. So I figured we could play a little truth game on an iTube livestream instead.”

“…iTube? A livestream?”

“Oh, right. You don’t know we opened a Guild channel, do you? Subscribe and hit Like. Don’t forget to turn on notifications.”

“…”

“Wow, we’re already at three hundred thousand subscribers. If this blows up, we might break ten million. Half the country will probably tune in.”

The smile vanished from Park Jihoon’s lips without a trace.

“You shouldn’t start something you can’t handle.”

“I’ll handle it.”

“Do you want to make every major Guild your enemy?”

“If I raise hell here, can you handle the fallout?”

“…”

Park Jihoon’s mouth snapped shut as though it had been glued.

After glaring at me with burning eyes for a while, he spat out a single sentence.

“Tell me what you want.”

“What I want?”

“We’ll accommodate your demands as much as possible. Don’t make this any bigger. Let’s negotiate and end it here.”

“Negotiate.”

“If we take this all the way, we’ll both come out wounded. You know that as well as I do.”

He was right.

If I were the only one who had to bear the consequences, I would have taken this all the way.

But the lives of countless people connected to the Peace Guild were at stake.

Someone’s friend, lover, family…

Their futures too.

I quietly licked my dry lips.

“What can you give me?”

“Money and power. And all kinds of benefits that will help the Peace Guild grow.”

“Didn’t you say the Peace Guild’s growth bothered you enough to send the Black Hunters?”

“Which is why we need to set boundaries.”

“You’re telling us not to stray outside the fence you build?”

“That’s right.”

The longer I listened to Park Jihoon's proposal, the clearer the picture became.

What we stood to gain in exchange for handing over the Peace Guild's prisoners and keeping quiet about the incident was substantial.

No, it was enormous.

Buildings and land. Exclusive rights to high-rank Gates currently controlled by Myeongdong Guild. Even a staggering amount of cash.

The overall deal looked good.

But…

"You left out the most important part."

"Those terms are already more than generous enough—what?"

Park Jihoon frowned.

"What did you just say?"

"I said you left out the most important part."

"You're insane. You're demanding even more?"

"To be honest, there's no point explaining all this to me. I understand that it's valuable, but our Guild Master and Team Leader Choi are the experts on which terms are good or bad for us."

"Then what exactly did I leave out?"

I stared at Park Jihoon.

"An apology."

"…What?"

"If you did something wrong, you should apologize. But the most important thing—an apology—is missing."

His offer was packed with extravagant terms, but there was no apology.

The one thing that should have come before everything else was nowhere to be found.

"Ha."

Park Jihoon let out an incredulous laugh. The way he looked me up and down made his anger and disbelief plain.

"Fine. I'm sorry. Happy now?"

"That's not how you apologize."

Crack.

The bones in Park Jihoon's tightly clenched fist shifted with an ugly pop.

A moment later, he drew a deep breath, looked me in the eye, and enunciated each word.

"I'm sorry."

"That's a little better."

"Are you satisfied now?"

I gave a small nod.

“But next time you do it in person, try putting a little more sincerity into it. Bow your head politely, too.”

“…What the hell are you talking about now?”

“What good does apologizing to me do? You need to apologize to the victim and his family.”

Park Jihoon’s eyelids trembled.

“You want me to apologize to that D-rank Hunter?”

“Why? Can’t do it?”

“I already told you we’d pay him compensation. It’s more money than most Hunters will ever see in their lives.”

“That works out nicely, then. A heartfelt apology accompanied by a massive compensation payment as a token of remorse should be even more effective.”

“You…”

I gently added one more remark as Park Jihoon glared daggers at me.

“If it hurts your pride, bring someone else along and apologize together.”

Myeongdong Guild Master Park Tae Seop, who had listened in silence until now, finally spoke.

“I’ll visit him in person and apologize. Sincerely.”

“At least you understand the basics, Guild Master. I suppose that makes you a slightly cleaner piece of shit.”

Cleaner shit.

At that moment, I couldn’t think of a more fitting—or more paradoxical—description.

But Park Tae Seop wasn’t the other suspect I had in mind.

I leaned forward in my chair and stared into Park Jihoon’s eyes.

“Bring the person who gave you your orders. Make that person apologize too.”

“…!”

A violent storm churned in his eyes.

It lasted only an instant, but that brief flash of agitation was more than enough to turn my suspicion into certainty.

“Fine. Guild Master Park Tae Seop just agreed, anyway.”

Park Jihoon continued in the calmest voice he could manage.

“We’ll go together and apologize.”

“Cut the bullshit. Bring that person here.”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

I rose with a quiet laugh and walked toward the reception sofa where Park Jihoon sat.

“No matter how much I thought about it, I just couldn’t make sense of it.”

I dropped into the seat across from him.

With the large solid-wood table between us, I slowly studied him as he pretended to remain calm.

His solid build. The muscles visible beneath his shirt.

And the power lurking within him.

It was immense and powerful.

Even without checking his Level, I could tell how wide the gap was between him and the Team 1 Leader.

“What couldn’t you make sense of?”

“How someone strong enough to chew up that Team Leader lying over there with one hand isn’t even a deputy team leader. He’s just an ordinary Hunter.”

“…!”

“Not to mention you show up for work so rarely that you might come in once a month. And from the way you spoke to the Team 1 Leader over the phone, you were practically his superior.”

There were too many suspicious details to count.

And as our conversation continued, those suspicions had gradually hardened into certainty.

“We’re discussing terms on this scale, but the man supposedly in charge stays silent while an ordinary team member with no position does all the talking… How am I supposed to interpret that, Guild Master Park Tae Seop?”

Myeongdong Guild Master Park Tae Seop held my gaze, then slowly closed his eyes.

That was answer enough.

I laughed quietly and looked at Park Jihoon.

“So bring that person here. I don’t know who it is, but bring them here and make them apologize first.”

Park Jihoon’s tightly sealed lips finally parted.

“And if I refuse?”

“Then we take this all the way.”

“You crazy bastard. Do you even know who that person is?”

“No. I don’t particularly want to know, either. But I do want to see that bastard come here, slam his head down, and apologize. Then I’ll be satisfied.”

Swish!

At that same instant, I shot out a hand at blinding speed.

Park Jihoon cried out in alarm.

“You bastard!”

Pap-pap-pap!

Our hands collided and tangled in an instant.
Five exchanges passed in the blink of an eye.
Crunch.
His wrist broke, and his eyes flew wide.
I seized his neatly waxed hair and slammed his head into the table.
BANG!
“Like this.”

Chapter 283

BANG!

The air in the office vibrated with a sharp hum.

Park Jihoon's forehead smashed through the table and slammed into the floor. With a sharp crack, spiderweb fractures spread across the ground.

"Guh."

I pressed my knee into his back, applying the principles of the Thousand-Catty Drop.

I stared at the back of his head in surprise.

Huh. Look at this bastard.

Modern Hunters had no concept of martial arts.

Even among close-combat types, it was extremely rare to find someone like Im Yeongjun, a Black Hunter who focused primarily on hand-to-hand combat. Most concentrated on weapons.

Because that was the better way to improve their survival rate.

But Park Jihoon was different. Though it had lasted only an instant, the movements he had shown were comparable to those of a Peak master from Murim.

It was a little clumsy, but it was almost like a grappling technique wielded by someone who had reached a higher realm.

I had underestimated him and been caught off guard. The fight had ended almost immediately, but the fact that he had exchanged moves with me five times already put his ability far beyond what I had expected.

Has this level of hand-to-hand combat survived into the modern era? Why hasn't anyone heard of it?

With those questions in mind, I asked.

"You. Where did you learn that just now?"

Park Jihoon answered in a strained voice.

"Let go right now, before you regret it."

"I see. Still full of energy, are you?"

BANG! BANG! BANG!

Once. Twice. Three times.

Every time I grabbed his hair and slammed his head down, a muffled groan escaped him. Blood spattered across the office floor, which had been spotless only moments ago.

As his body went limp, Park Tae Seop, who had been observing the situation, suddenly spoke.

"That's enough."

“Is this bastard your son, Guild Master?”

“Would he be my son?”

“Then is he your daughter?”

“Obviously not that, either.”

“Then this isn’t your problem. If you cross the line here, I can’t guarantee what I’ll do.”

Park Tae Seop’s eyebrow twitched.

“You’ve got quite a spicy tongue.”

“My hands are even spicier. My old nickname was the Haengsin-dong Fire-Chicken Stir-Fried Hand.[1510]… Want a taste?”

“I have a reputation to uphold. I have no intention of fighting someone as young and green as you.”

Park Tae Seop uncrossed his arms and continued.

“But if that fellow is seriously injured, it will put me in a difficult position. He’s an important business partner.”

“He’s a manager sent by your business partner, isn’t he? No, seeing how he pushes you around, it’s embarrassing to even call you partners. You’re practically a figurehead. Does he have something on you?”

I must have struck a nerve, because he made a show of frowning.

“You’re more perceptive than I expected. Though I heard you weren’t very bright.”

I didn’t need to ask which bastard had said that.

I grabbed Park Jihoon’s wax-stiffened hair even more roughly and answered.

“I’m a slow learner. But once I learn something, I don’t forget it.”

“He learned his lesson properly this time, so let him go now.”

“I was planning to do that anyway.”

As I lifted Park Jihoon by the hair, Park Tae Seop gave a small nod.

“Good thinking…”

I drove the fistful of hair back down with all my strength.

BANG!

One more time.

CRUNCH!

The floor shattered beneath the deafening impact. As Park Jihoon flopped around like a raw fish, I drove my toe into his solar plexus.

THUD!

He flew backward and slid all the way to the door.

“Ghk!”

[1510] *Buldak-bokkeum-myeon* means “fire-chicken stir-fried noodles.” The nickname replaces *myeon* (“noodles”) with *son* (“hand”).

The impact jolted him awake. He trembled violently and spat out a mouthful of blood.

"…"

Park Tae Seop was unable to continue speaking, so I addressed him.

"I let him go. There. Happy?"

"You… You're quite something."

"Am I really as bad as the bastard who cuts people's arms off and calls it a warning?"

"I don't particularly like that fellow myself, but you would've been better off taking my advice."

His expression and voice had turned rigid.

He was serious.

Rather than feeling afraid, I became curious. Who was this person that even Park Tae Seop—a war hero of the Great Cataclysm and one of Korea's top rankers—was wary of?

I asked with a questioning look.

"Who is it? That bastard only called him 'that person.'"

"I can't tell you. Even if I did, you'd only resent me later."

"Why make such a big deal out of it? Is that person Asmodeus or something?"

"If you made him your enemy, you'd be better off facing the Demon King. At least then, the whole world would fight alongside you… But what are you doing right now?"

Park Tae Seop stared at me wide-eyed.

Or, to be precise, at the phone in my hand.

"I'm looking at this phone."

"Suddenly?"

"Yes."

He had the exact expression of a man wondering what kind of lunatic he was dealing with.

Completely baffled, Park Tae Seop asked, "What are you doing with it?"

"What do you think? Since you won't tell me, I'm trying to find his number myself."

"His number?"

"Yes. That person's number."

"Wait. Is that…?"

"That's right. I took it from that bastard's pocket earlier."

Park Tae Seop's eyes widened. Park Jihoon, who had been coughing up blood, shouted as though he had forgotten his pain.

“Give it back right now!”

“Nope. Can’t.”

I toyed with the mysterious phone, whose make I couldn’t identify.

It looked completely different from the phone I had seen when I visited his officetel[1511] last time. There was no way he had replaced it in the past few days, so it was probably a separate phone he kept for secret communications.

It wasn’t that strange. Even people secretly cheating on their partners carried two or three phones.

He has so many secrets, after all.

When I touched the screen, two messages appeared alongside a lock icon. One asked for a fingerprint, and the other for an iris scan.

I could understand the fingerprint part, but what the hell was with the iris scan?

I beckoned to Park Jihoon, who was staggering to his feet.

“Hey. Come here. Let it scan your fingerprint and iris.”

“Jin Taekyung, you crazy bastard. Do you even know what you’re doing?”

“Yeah, I know. So get over here and put your eye and finger against it before I rip them out.”

“Don’t rush me. I was planning to do that without you telling me.”

Park Jihoon ground his teeth with a crunch and wiped at the corner of his mouth.

But unlike before, when he had been gasping for breath, he was now brimming with strength.

Aside from the blood covering him here and there, his cracked forehead and broken nose had already healed completely. His stamina was as good as new.

Only then did I notice a small reinforced-glass vial rolling around by his feet.

“A potion?”

“When there’s an enemy in front of you, never let your attention wander until the very end. Didn’t they teach you that at the training center?”

He must have taken out the hidden potion and gulped it down during the brief moment I was looking at my phone. I shrugged.

“That only matters when the two sides are evenly matched. That’s not the case here, is it?”

“What?”

“I don’t know where you learned that or who taught you, but…”

As I circulated my qi according to the formula of the Fire Gate Divine Technique, the fire dragon coiled within my dantian awakened.

I fixed Park Jihoon with glowing, reddish eyes.

“You and I are in different classes, you fucking scrub.”

[1511] An *officetel* is a Korean building with units designed for both office and residential use.

The next moment, the fire dragon formed from a jiazi's[1512] worth of Scorching Yang Qi scattered into hundreds of streams. As they dispersed, they awakened my acupoints and raced forward without restraint.

The internal energy met again at a single destination and merged into one.

Disperse, compress. And…

Release.

WHOOSH!

Early winter was already setting in, but the frigid office transformed into the sweltering heat of midsummer beneath a blazing sun. An enormous burst of fiery qi erupted in an instant and surged through the room.

"Hah."

I exhaled a scorching breath.

Beyond the wavering heat haze, I saw a man whose face was filled with shock. His expression had gone rigid, and turbulent waves churned in his eyes.

"You… You…"

Park Jihoon's voice emerged as a groan.

"How?"

"I told you. We're different."

As though someone had doused him in ice water, he shuddered and bit down on his lip. He bit so hard that the flesh split at once and blood began to flow.

"This… This is impossible. How could you…?"

The man muttered with a twisted expression, then abruptly opened his mouth.

"I'm going to need your help."

There was no question who he was addressing.

Park Tae Seop, Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild, had been watching me with astonishment. He answered in a heavy voice.

"Is there any way for me to refuse that proposal?"

"No."

"And if I refuse anyway?"

"Guaranteed rewards and punishments according to the choice you make. You know how 'that person' operates, Guild Master."

"…I'm sick to death of this."

Park Tae Seop sighed and pulled a sixty-centimeter-long[1513] rod from his waist. When he stroked the Magic Gem attached to its end, a snow-white blade surged upward.

HSSSSSS!

"Don't blame me."

[1512] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[1513] Sixty centimeters is about 23.6 in.

With that bitter remark, he pointed the sword at me. Blue aura engulfed its blade.

My opponent was a hero of the Great Cataclysm and one of Korea's top ten rankers. An immense aura rose from his body to confront my Scorching Yang Qi.

With a powerful ally at his side, Park Jihoon smiled coldly.

"You're finished."

"Finished?"

I laughed aloud.

Since I had heard he went to Hankuk University,[1514] I had assumed he was at least somewhat intelligent. But it seemed he had completely forgotten what I'd told him last time.

"I'm the one who decides whether this ends, you fucking idiot."

Park Jihoon had forced me onto the starting line and pulled the trigger to signal the beginning of the race. But he had failed to anticipate the most important thing.

This race had no finish line.

And that wherever I stopped was the finish line.

Open Inventory.

Summon White Flame.

FWOOSH!

I stepped forward amid the flames.

Blue fire streamed along the spearhead, scorching everything around it as it surged toward the enemy.

"Haah!"

With a powerful battle cry, a massive greatsword came flying at me. The blue aura gathered at its tip was denser and longer than anything I had ever seen in reality.

As expected of one of Korea's top rankers.

Internal energy and mana.

The names were different, but their essence was the same. In that sense, the energy Park Tae Seop possessed exceeded mine.

But…

That's as far as it goes.

At the thought, I sprang upward.

My hair narrowly grazed the ceiling as the blade sweeping toward my waist cut through empty air.

WHOOM! CLANG-CLANG-CLANG!

[1514] Hankuk University is presented as the country's most prestigious university.

The tremendous pressure wave swept everything away. The reinforced glass covering one side of the office shattered and plummeted toward the ground.

Before the screams from below could reach me, I brought the spearhead down toward the crown of Park Tae Seop's head.

WHOOSH! BANG!

With a deafening roar, Park Tae Seop's knee struck the floor.

His eyes widened in shock as he hurriedly blocked the attack with the shield in his other hand.

"What is this?"

By now, he must have felt as though a massive boulder weighing ten thousand geun[1515] was crushing him.

That was partly the difference in our physical abilities and partly the gap created by the way we used our energy.

Hunters really aren't very efficient.

In contrast, Murim cultivation techniques explosively increased the efficiency of internal energy. That was why renowned great powers like the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were so strong.

Superior internal cultivation techniques formed the heart of the martial arts they wielded.

Only when all those tiny gears meshed together with perfect precision could an art truly be called divine.

Disperse, compress, release.

Internal energy was like a scarce resource. You had to draw it out only when absolutely necessary and use it to maximum effect.

Even Park Tae Seop, one of Korea's top rankers, had not completely escaped that limitation.

BANG! BANG! BOOM!

The instant Park Tae Seop's shield split in half after blocking a total of four attacks, a flash streaked toward my side.

"Die!"

The wielder of the thin, sharp rapier could only be Park Jihoon.

Just as I thought I had dodged it, the aura extending from the blade's tip suddenly lengthened and grazed my side.

SIZZLE!

Disappointment flashed across Park Jihoon's face.

His aura had only cut through my clothes and passed by.

I checked my uninjured side and licked my lips.

[1515] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,000 lb).

"…This is pretty interesting."

"Interesting? You're not afraid?"

"Did the guy you call 'that person' or whatever teach you?"

"Shut your mouth. You're not worthy of even speaking of that person."

"Huh. So I was right. This isn't some kind of cult, is it?"

"You son of a—!"

WHOOM! SHH-SHH-SHHK!

Park Tae Seop's greatsword came from the right, while Park Jihoon's rapier flew in from the left.

Watching the two men tear through the space between us, I thrust out both arms.

BANG! BOOM!

I blocked Park Tae Seop's greatsword with White Flame and Park Jihoon's rapier with the dagger I had just summoned, then smoothly rotated my wrists.

KRRRANG!

The four blades, locked in a tense clash, tangled around one another.

I remembered my duel with Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

His sword, which had let everything flow past.

His movements.

And I put them into practice.

Flow.

Sliiide.

The spearhead and dagger slipped forward like snakes. Neither the massive greatsword nor the slender rapier could block their path.

A moment later, the keen edges of my two weapons touched their throats.

Swish.

"Drop your weapons."

"…!"

"…!"

Two shocked gazes turned toward me.

Park Jihoon spoke in a voice filled with rage and despair.

"How could you…?"

"You didn't hear me, did you?"

CRACK!

There was no hesitation.

I raised my foot and drove it down onto his knee. Cartilage shattered, and a scream burst from him.

"Aaaaargh!"

"We're down two arms on our side. One leg doesn't balance the books."

I was about to crush his remaining knee when—

“I think that should be enough.”

An unfamiliar voice pierced my ears.

It was impossibly deep and low. A chill ran down my spine, and every fine hair on my body stood on end.

This was…

A Supreme Peak master?

Chapter 284

"I think that's enough."

I hadn't expected that.

The voice from behind me sent a chill through my mind, as though someone had dumped ice water over my head.

When did he get there?

I hadn't sensed his presence. Even considering that I'd been in the middle of a fight, that should have been impossible.

If he had slipped past senses honed to the very edge of Peak, there was only one answer.

A Supreme Peak master.

I slowly turned around. A man stood amid the rubble of a wall brought down in the fighting, gazing steadily at me.

"Nice to meet you."

He was a middle-aged man who looked to be in his early forties, with bold features drawn in strong brushstrokes and a solid build that even his clothes couldn't conceal.

And…

He's strong.

The moment I sensed the qi coiled within him, my heart sank. At the same time, all my accumulated experience and keenly honed instincts whispered a warning.

The middle-aged man before me was a Supreme Peak master beyond anything I could handle in my current state.

"Young man, you've got good instincts. Better than I expected."

The middle-aged man looked me over with interest, then suddenly tilted his head.

"Or is it because you recognize my face?"

"Both."

His appearance had shaken me badly.

I tried my best to look calm, but I couldn't hide the crack in my voice or the tremor in my eyes.

"Well, it's not as if my face has only been plastered around once or twice."

The middle-aged man nodded as if it were nothing and strode forward.

He crossed the wrecked office and held out his hand.

"Nice to meet you. I'm Lee Jungryong."

A short, simple introduction.

But the meaning and influence carried by the three characters of Lee Jungryong's name were anything but short or simple.

He was the kind of man who could use his face and name as identification anywhere in the world, not just in Korea.

The second-in-command of Ares Guild. And one of Korea's two S-rank Hunters.

That was Lee Jungryong.

A powerful man who wielded absolute authority over Ares Guild in place of its Guild Master, the other S-rank Hunter.

Ares Guild was said to rank among the top five Guilds in the world. Its influence over Hunters was immense, to say nothing of politics and the economy.

People even said that Korea had two Blue Houses.[1516]

Why had someone so powerful appeared here of all places, at this exact moment?

Fuck. It's obvious.

Suddenly, the conversation I'd had with Park Tae Seop flashed through my mind.

"Who is he? That bastard earlier only called him 'that person.'"

I can't tell you. Even if I did, you'd only resent me later.

Why make such a big deal out of it? Is that person Asmodeus or something?

If you made him your enemy, it would be better if he were the Demon King. At least then, the whole world would fight alongside you.

The answer had already formed in my mind.

If Lee Jungryong was the "that person" Park Jihoon had mentioned, and Ares Guild was behind this whole affair, every piece fell perfectly into place.

This is turning into a real goddamn mess.

The unexpected arrival of such a major figure made my blood run cold.

Unlike me, frozen stiff, Lee Jungryong smiled gently and spoke.

"I've heard a great deal about you. You look much better in person than you do on television."

"Thank you."

"You don't look happy to see me at all."

"How could that be? You're an S-rank Hunter recognized throughout the world."

"It's an empty reputation. I'm nowhere near the Guild Master. Anyway…"

Still wearing his distinctive smile, Lee Jungryong opened and closed his outstretched hand.

"When are you going to shake my hand? This is starting to get embarrassing."

Watching his good-natured smile and listening to the easy joke, I had one thought.

This man has at least a hundred snakes coiled in his belly.

And I hated snakes.

"I'm sorry, but I don't have a hand free right now."

[1516] The Blue House was the South Korean president's residence and office. Calling Ares Guild a second Blue House compares its power to that of the presidency.

“Is that really a problem? Just put down whatever you’re holding and it’ll be easily resolved.”

“I can’t drop a problem that needs to be dealt with right now just for a handshake.”

I tightened my grip on the weapons in each hand.

Swish.

With a faint sound, thin lines of blood appeared across Park Tae Seop’s and Park Jihoon’s throats.

The two men had closed their eyes and pressed their lips tightly together the moment Lee Jungryong appeared. Even so, I could sense something like resolve from them.

“I hear you’re quite close with these two gentlemen. Why don’t you at least say hello?”

“Close? Me?”

Lee Jungryong let out a hearty laugh.

“I’ve known Guild Master Park since the Great Cataclysm, so we’re at least acquainted. Isn’t that right?”

Park Tae Seop, Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild, bit his lip before answering.

“It’s been a long time, Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong.”

“Yes, it has. But what happened here?”

“There was an unpleasant incident… I apologize for letting you see me in such a sorry state.”

“I don’t know what sort of misunderstanding there has been, but surely it can be settled through conversation. And who is that young man beside you?”

“He’s a member of my Guild. He’s been with us ever since he completed his training center course.”

Park Jihoon spoke in a trembling voice.

“Nice to meet you. I’m Park Jihoon of Myeongdong Guild’s Team 1.”

“…!”

I wasn’t surprised that Lee Jungryong spoke down to Park Tae Seop despite looking at least ten years younger than him.

I was surprised by their shamelessness.

Everyone here knew that Lee Jungryong was the one who had given Park Jihoon his first orders.

Yet the exchange I had just witnessed between the three men could mean only one thing.

The lizard’s tail.

The old lizard, already prepared to cut off its tail, smiled gently at me.

“See? I’ve never even met that young man before, and Guild Master Park and I merely exchange the occasional greeting.”

I let out a hollow laugh.

“By ‘exchanging greetings,‘ do you mean secretly sending Black Hunters to cut off the arm of some innocent person?”

“Black Hunters? Enough. Your delusions are getting out of hand. In any case, regarding Guild Master Park…”

He shook his head and continued.

“I think I may be able to help a little with that problem.”

“Help?”

“Yes, help. The problem needs to be resolved, doesn’t it?”

My earlier thought had been only half right. The lizard wasn’t planning to cut off its tail just yet. He wanted to clean up the mess.

Lee Jungryong’s gaze met mine. A bead of cold sweat that had formed at some point trickled down my neck.

This was both an offer and a warning.

Let these men go.

But…

“It’s a personal matter, so I don’t think that’ll be possible.”

I would decide whether I stopped here or kept going.

I had already made up my mind.

“Hmm? Ha ha.”

Lee Jungryong laughed aloud and regarded me with amusement.

“Young man, you’ve got quite a bit of grit. Plenty of nerve, too.”

“I hear that fairly often.”

“What about arrogant?”

“I hear that even more.”

“High-spirited young men are often misunderstood.”

“I think so too.”

“Yes. I’m glad you understand, but…”

An unreadable light flashed in Lee Jungryong’s eyes.

“Don’t you think it’s time you changed?”

“How?”

“You’re a well-known public figure, and you’re nearing thirty. It would be best to avoid those sorts of misunderstandings.”

“I appreciate the advice, but I’m not planning to change yet.”

“Why not?”

“Because the people who tell me that are always fucking idiots whose only achievement is getting older. There’s no reason to run away just because a few neighborhood mutts are blocking the road.”

“You wouldn’t enjoy being bitten by a vicious dog.”

“No matter how vicious it is, a dog is still a dog. No offense, but I consider myself at least a wolf.”

“A wolf… Then what would you do if the creature blocking your path wasn’t a dog, but a tiger?”

The corners of Lee Jungryong’s mouth curved gently upward.

He was the tiger.

A tiger blocking my path. A predator with teeth and claws capable of killing a wolf.

“I’d run. A wolf can’t beat a tiger.”

“Exactly.”

“But add a few details to the setup, and the wolf might still attack.”

“Details?”

“Yes. For example…”

I continued slowly as I looked at Lee Jungryong.

“What if that tiger was the bastard who badly hurt the wolf’s friend? Something like that.”

He studied me with a peculiar expression.

“It seems the wolf’s friend was badly hurt.”

“Both his legs were cut off. How could he not be? He has a young child, too.”

“That’s an awfully detailed setup.”

“I came up with it while trying to make the setup plausible. It’s only hypothetical, so don’t worry about it.”

“If that’s all it is.”

Lee Jungryong shrugged.

“Still, a wolf taking on a tiger for his friend… He’s certainly loyal.”

“You’d understand if you watched a documentary about wolves. Their loyalty is no joke.”

“But it would be reckless.”

“Why?”

“Because attacking a tiger would get him killed.”

I let out a quiet laugh.

“You never know. Maybe a young, strong wolf could beat an old tiger.”

“…A tiger losing to a wolf? That doesn’t sound like a very well-made documentary.”

“I enjoyed it. The part where every animal in the mountains came running to feast on the tiger’s corpse after the wolf won was especially memorable.”

“…”

For the first time, the smile vanished from Lee Jungryong’s face.

Naturally. He had understood the meaning behind my words.

Watching his face stiffen felt like finally dislodging the formula that had been stuck in my throat since infancy.

“You’re irritating. More than I expected.”

After a brief silence, he spoke again.

Lee Jungryong slowly withdrew the hand he had kept extended until now.

“What do you want?”

I answered without hesitation.

“An apology and compensation. And one person’s life.”

“A life?”

“Yes. I want one person’s life.”

Park Jihoon’s neck twitched.

A tremor traveled through the dagger pressed against his throat. He hadn’t made a sound since Lee Jungryong appeared, but now he was trembling with fear of death.

“That’s out of the question. I can’t allow it.”

“I’m not asking for permission. I’m making a demand.”

“Learn to distinguish courage from recklessness. I’m a patient man, but I’m also quite fickle.”

“I’m short on basic decency, so I can’t rest until I’ve paid back at least as much as I received.”

“Your demand is excessive. The compensation should already be more than enough.”

“Who settles for getting back the principal? I want the interest too—compound interest.”

“And if I refuse?”

“Do you remember the documentary I mentioned?”

“…!”

“Tiger hide or not, do you really think a wolf’s teeth won’t sink into it?”

Lee Jungryong’s gaze sank heavily as he looked at me.

In the strangely tranquil silence, his mouth slowly opened.

“You truly don’t know how frightening a tiger can be.”

WHOOSH!

Before he had even finished speaking, a palm wreathed in red aura shot toward my chest.

Only five steps separated us. I made my decision in an instant.

White Flame. Unequip.

As White Flame was stored in my Inventory, I thrust out my freed right hand.

Disperse, compress, release.

The fire dragon that had been waiting for its chance to awaken transformed into blue flames and settled into my palm.

Flame Divine Palm, with everything I had.

Our palms collided.

BOOOOOOM!

A deafening roar left my ears ringing as the entire building shook like it had been struck by an earthquake.

I took the brunt of the impact.

I danced three steps backward and coughed up a mouthful of blood surging from deep within my lungs.

“Cough!”

Through the pale dust falling from the ceiling, I saw Lee Jungryong standing firmly in place.

“You…”

His eyes were filled with surprise.

But I was just as shocked.

I had felt him manipulate qi in a way I never could have encountered in the modern world.

He’s different. He’s no ordinary Hunter.

We had exchanged only a single blow, but that was enough.

Lee Jungryong’s strike had resembled the palm technique of a Supreme Peak master. He didn’t merely know how to use his qi properly. He could do far more than that.

So this is an S-rank Hunter.

The power I had felt in that brief instant rivaled the great fiends I had encountered at Shaolin, the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts.

What kind of monster is this?

I had never expected to experience anything like this in the modern world.

Lee Jungryong stared wide-eyed at me as I swallowed the blood in my mouth, gripping Park Jihoon in one hand and the dagger in the other.

“How could someone as young as you know that method…?”

That method?

He was probably referring to an internal energy cultivation technique in those terms.

I was about to answer, but instead I bared my bloodstained teeth in a grin.

“I’m taking what I demanded.”

At the same time, I plunged the dagger into Park Jihoon’s chest.

Shnk. Shnk-shnk-shnk!

A scream burst from his mouth along with a spray of blood.

“Aaaaargh! Master!”

I’d wondered how this bastard knew about it. Now I saw—they were master and Disciple.

“Stop!”

Even as he shouted, Lee Jungryong couldn’t easily take a step forward.

Every time he tried, I pressed the dagger tight against Park Jihoon’s throat.

“Now, now. If you want to save your adorable Disciple, you’d better stay right there.”

“…!”

Shnk! Shnk-shnk!

Without hesitation, I drove the dagger down again and again. I hacked indiscriminately at his upper body, avoiding his heart, then tore through the muscles of his thigh.

Slash!

I cut down along his calf and severed the tendons in his ankle. Then I straightened my back, which I had briefly bent, and slashed diagonally upward through his shoulder.

Slash! SPLASH!

“Aaaaaaargh!”

A horrific scream.

Uncle Kkeokjeong must have screamed like that too. He must have passed out from the unbearable pain and woken again, over and over, screaming each time.

And that wasn’t all. The wife who saw her husband return without both arms had her heart butchered as well.

“Save your screams. There’s still one left.”

“…!”

Slash! Thud!

Park Jihoon’s body, now missing both arms, trembled violently.

“Ghk… guh…”

He had screamed so much that his voice had gone completely hoarse. Only strange noises escaped his throat.

I seized him by the hair. His once-neat, waxed hair was drenched in blood.

“P-please… spare me…”

My blood was boiling hotter than ever, but the voice that slipped through my lips was colder than ice.

“Jihoon.”

“Please. I’m sorry…”

“I had to move away so suddenly back then that I never got to say this.”

I stared into his bloodshot eyes and delivered a congratulatory message ten years past its expiration date.

“Congratulations on graduating, you fucking bastard.”

I hurled him aside.

Thud.

Lee Jungryong picked up the sprawled man in his arms. His eyes burned fiercely.

“You bastard!”

“I left him alive. Whether he’ll ever be a Hunter again, I can’t promise.”

“Do you truly want to die?”

“How about we keep going? Bring down this entire building and let half of Korea find out what happened here. That doesn’t sound so bad to me.”

Lee Jungryong’s face twisted hideously.

Chapter 285

How dare you do this to my Disciple!

I only paid him back in kind. That settles the principal, so consult your Guild's leadership about the remaining compound interest.

…You bastard.

I'll take that as your agreement.

I will never forget what happened today.

That was the conversation we'd had only a few minutes ago.

Lee Jungryong had left after delivering that final line, every word dripping with killing intent.

He had administered emergency treatment with a potion, but Park Jihoon's wounds were too severe for potions alone to heal. With his Disciple in that condition, he must have been in a hurry to get him treated.

"Phew."

Once Lee Jungryong's presence, which I could still sense in the distance, disappeared completely, a sigh of relief escaped me.

"Man, that was exhausting."

The moment I released the tension I'd held on to until the very end, all the strength drained from my body.

I was tired. My clash with Lee Jungryong had left me with a slight Internal Injury, but the mental exhaustion was even worse.

I really caused one hell of a mess today.

Today, I had made an S-rank Hunter recognized throughout the world and a colossal Guild my enemies.

It had been a precarious tightrope walk with a sheer, bottomless cliff as the stage.

Lee Jungryong and I had met in the middle of that tightrope, and in the end, he had been the one to back down.

He had no choice. I hit him exactly where it mattered.

People with a lot to lose were bound to fear danger.

If the tiger known as Lee Jungryong—or the tiger known as Ares Guild—were to fall, the mountain lord's[1517] honor would hit the ground, and its carcass would become an excellent meal for the animals of the forest—in other words, its competitors.

Of course, the cleanest solution would've been Silencing the Witnesses, but…

Lee Jungryong knew I wasn't an easy opponent.

[1517] *San-gun* (□□), meaning "mountain lord," is a traditional epithet for a tiger.

A single clash had confirmed that he held the upper hand, but it had also been enough for him to realize that the wolf before him posed a genuine threat.

I wiped the blood from the corner of my mouth and thought.

Three steps.

Today, I had taken three steps back against Lee Jungryong.

But today's three steps would soon become two, and before long, two would become one.

And after that…

I'll surpass you.

I had never seen any documentary where a wolf defeated a tiger one-on-one, despite what I'd told Lee Jungryong.

But I had the potential to grow without end. Just like my epithet, the Hidden Dragon.

By then, my Guild and I will both be stronger than you ever imagined.

Revenge for Im Kkeokjeong wasn't the only thing I had gained from this incident. I had also secured a golden opportunity for the Peace Guild to grow.

If we had been frightened into backing down when the Black Hunter first attacked, the Peace Guild would have remained just another mid-sized Guild. But because we had fought back, we had won both revenge and compensation. What came next would depend on Team Leader Choi.

He'll handle it well.

A conversation I'd had with Team Leader Choi several hours earlier suddenly came to mind.

"What are you planning to do?"

"Hard to say. If my hunch is right, I might see red, and even I don't know what I'll do."

"Are you thinking of storming Myeongdong Guild?"

"I can't promise I'm not."

Song Song had called me crazy after hearing that, while Butler Kim had only stared at me in silence.

But Team Leader Choi had reacted differently.

What he said went far beyond anything I'd expected.

"Then go."

"Excuse me?"

"To Myeongdong Guild. Go smash the place up and turn it upside down. Ah, I'm not telling you to collapse a building in the middle of Seoul and kill people. If you go too far, we might end up using a prison as our Guild house."

"…I thought you'd try to stop me."

“I would have, if you weren’t Jin Taekyung. I would’ve racked my brain for some other solution.”

“Then why?”

“You may look reckless at first glance, Mr. Jin, but you always act with the worst possible outcome in mind. And you always bring back the best possible result.”

“Are you really sure about this?”

“I intend to make the Peace Guild the greatest Guild in the world. If we back down when one of our Guild members has been attacked, we can never become the best in the world.”

“Then you really want me to…”

“Do it. Whatever happens, I’ll take responsibility.”

Team Leader Choi’s final words still seemed to echo vividly in my ears.

“I trust you, Mr. Jin. Perhaps even more than I trust myself.”

I had repaid the boundless trust he’d placed in me.

I had given Park Jihoon more than Im Kkeokjeong had suffered, and I had tacitly secured apologies and compensation from enemies no one could dare approach.

The greatest Guild in the world, huh?

Remembering Team Leader Choi’s bold ambition, I let out a quiet laugh.

I took out my phone and made a call.

Someone answered almost before it had begun ringing.

“Yes. This is Choi Minwoo.”

Team Leader Choi. The man himself.

“I have a lot to tell you. Where should I go?”

“Mr. Jin! You’re alive!”

“…?”

“I thought you were dead. Is this really Jin Taekyung?”

“…”

You said you trusted me more than yourself, you son of a bitch…

“Jihoon! Wake up!”

A master’s anguished cry for his young Disciple rang out alongside hurried footsteps.

Park Tae Seop, the Guild Master of Myeongdong Guild, followed close behind Lee Jungryong and stared at his back in surprise.

Did Lee Jungryong have this side to him?

Park Tae Seop had watched Lee Jungryong for many years.

During the Great Cataclysm, he had merely thought of him as someone who was strangely difficult to approach.

But after the war ended and Ares Guild was established, Lee Jungryong seized real power within it. Only then did Park Tae Seop come to understand his true nature.

Hard as steel. Sly as a viper. A man who committed acts that would make others shudder without the slightest hesitation.

That was Lee Jungryong in Park Tae Seop's eyes—a man he never wanted to face as either an enemy or an ally.

So he's human after all.

But the strange impression Park Tae Seop had felt vanished without a trace the moment they emerged from the long corridor and entered the hall.

"Welcome."

"…!"

The speaker was a middle-aged man. His movements were as crisp and disciplined as a soldier's, and even his black suit couldn't conceal his supremely trained physique.

The same was true of the twenty men and women standing behind him like iron towers. Each wore the emblem of Ares Guild over their chest.

I didn't sense any of them.

That wasn't the only shock awaiting Park Tae Seop.

He looked past the middle-aged man and spotted roughly a hundred Myeongdong Guild members sprawled across the floor. His eyes widened.

"What is the meaning of this…?"

The middle-aged man answered in a dry voice.

"We merely put them to sleep with sleep magic. For now."

For now.

The words carried a clear implication. At the moment, they were merely asleep under the influence of magic.

But they could just as easily be put to sleep forever.

Park Tae Seop was about to shout in fury when—

"Is there a problem?"

Lee Jungryong slowly turned around.

The instant Park Tae Seop saw his face, he realized how gravely mistaken he had been.

It was all an act.

Lee Jungryong's face was devoid of emotion, his eyes deep and cold. There was no trace of his hurried footsteps or the anguished cries of a master fearing for his Disciple's life.

An icy chill crept up Park Tae Seop's spine.

"Guild Master Park."

There was a blade hidden in Lee Jungryong's gentle voice. It was as though venom dripped from the viper's tongue every time it moved.

"Was it about twenty years ago? One day, you came to me and dropped to your knees without warning."

"…!"

"Do you still remember?"

"…Of course."

Park Tae Seop clenched his teeth.

How could he possibly forget? Nearly twenty years had passed, but the desperation he'd felt then remained etched into his bones.

A string of massive business failures, debts totaling an enormous sum, and the looks people gave him as though they were staring at a failure…

To Park Tae Seop, it had been a living hell worse than the Great Cataclysm.

After being turned away by countless acquaintances, he had finally sought out Lee Jungryong.

Lee Jungryong had gazed down at the kneeling Park Tae Seop and asked him a single question.

If I help you, what can you do for me?

Park Tae Seop had answered without hesitation.

Anything.

I like that answer.

What would have happened if he hadn't said those words?

He had asked himself that question hundreds, even thousands of times over the past twenty years, but it was meaningless. He had already come too far to turn back.

No favor came without a price, and he had been forced to commit every manner of crime for Lee Jungryong.

By the time he came to his senses, he was already being dragged along by a leash around his neck.

"Whenever I look at you these days, Guild Master Park, I can't help thinking about that day. Everything you said when you came to me back then is beginning to sound hollow."

"How could that be?"

"No, that's simply human nature. No matter how much someone owes you, they soon forget their gratitude and begin piling up complaints. Save a man from freezing to death, and he changes his tune the moment he warms himself by the fire. What can you do? Ha ha."

"…"

Despite the upward curl of his lips, Lee Jungryong's eyes were as cold as ice.

When Park Tae Seop lowered his head, his expression rigid, Lee Jungryong continued in a gentler voice.

"I only brought it up because I hope we'll continue working well together. Your Guild members will be perfectly safe, so don't worry. Isn't that right, Team Leader Seok?"

The middle-aged man responsible for Lee Jungryong's security, Team Leader Seok, answered in a flat voice.

"Of course."

"Well, I should be on my way. I'll see you again."

Pat, pat.

Park Tae Seop stood frozen as Lee Jungryong patted him on the shoulder and walked away.

Inside the descending elevator, Team Leader Seok spoke.

"Shall I take care of him?"

"Who? Ah, Park Tae Seop."

"Yes. His expression looked rather uneasy."

"That man's every thought shows on his face. He was obedient enough for the first few years, but once he got warm and well-fed, he began entertaining other ideas."

"He knows too much. He also handled this incident so poorly that the fallout reached you, Vice Guild Master."

For the first time, emotion entered Team Leader Seok's voice.

Anger.

Seeing the man's unwavering loyalty, Lee Jungryong smiled faintly.

"Leave him alone for now. We've only just started tasting the dish. Of course it's still bland."

"Excuse me?"

At that moment, the elevator doors opened with a ding.

Lee Jungryong continued as he walked.

"I'm saying I only gave them a little prod. I wanted to see how they would react."

"Then…?"

"You occasionally underestimate me. If I had truly set my mind to it, would I have entrusted the job to half-baked fools like them?"

Team Leader Seok let out a low exclamation.

"You anticipated all of this."

“I’ve barely taken a single spoonful to taste it. If it doesn’t suit my palate, I can always add some salt and pepper.”

“As expected of you, Vice Guild Master.”

Lee Jungryong smiled gently at the admiration in Team Leader Seok’s eyes.

But his true thoughts were different. There was something he couldn’t reveal even to Team Leader Seok, his right-hand man.

Jin Taekyung is no ordinary bastard.

From the beginning, it had been the Peace Guild that bothered Lee Jungryong, not Jin Taekyung.

Even if he had personally intervened, he couldn’t guarantee that something like this wouldn’t have happened. After all, he wasn’t the sort of man who used a cleaver meant for cattle to kill a chicken.

It was certainly efficient, but if an unforeseen variable appeared, the entire plan could go awry.

Who would’ve thought there was a wolf hiding among the chickens?

Lee Jungryong rubbed his tingling wrist.

For a moment, he had felt tremendous heat and power radiating from the young man. It was far too strong to dismiss as some fresh-faced brat’s cute little display.

He knew how to control mana properly. Where could a man who was only an F-rank Hunter until recently have learned…?

He did have a fairly good idea.

After finishing that thought, Lee Jungryong addressed Team Leader Seok.

“Keep a close eye on Jin Taekyung.”

“Don’t worry. If he becomes a nuisance, I’ll deal with him personally.”

Team Leader Seok had always been reliable. He was a born fighting prodigy and the finest of all the youths Lee Jungryong had personally selected and trained. His skill was beyond question. Even a high-level ranker like Park Tae Seop was no match for him.

But a question suddenly occurred to Lee Jungryong.

Was Team Leader Seok really superior to Jin Taekyung?

“Team Leader Seok. No, Go Jun.”

His form of address had shifted from the man’s position to his name.

Team Leader Seok understood the meaning immediately. If he had lacked even that much perception, he could never have become Lee Jungryong’s prized Disciple.

“Yes, Master.”

“Hmm. It’s nothing. I entertained an absurd thought for a moment.”

Lee Jungryong clicked his tongue softly and walked out through the main entrance.

Five men and women were waiting outside the building, dressed in robes covered with elaborate patterns and carrying staffs.

"We greet the Vice Guild Master."

"Those outfits are certainly gaudy. Can't you dress a little more ordinarily?"

"They'll look ordinary to everyone else."

They were A-rank mages under Lee Jungryong's direct command.

Just as the oldest-looking mage had said, not one of the hundreds of people hurrying along the sidewalk paid them any attention.

None of those people even knew that an incredible battle had taken place directly above them—one that had nearly brought down a high-rise building.

"This is why magic is so convenient."

The mages had used brute force to blanket everything within a radius of roughly two hundred meters[1518] with illusion magic. Only the handpicked A-rank mages of Ares Guild could pull off something on that scale.

They would remain there and maintain the illusion until the entire aftermath had been dealt with.

"Good. Use that convenient magic of yours to make sure no rumors get out. If anyone looks dangerous, use mental magic to tamper with their memories."

"Yes, sir. Understood. But that man is badly injured."

"Ah, him?"

Lee Jungryong glanced at Park Jihoon, who was being carried on the back of a Hunter from his security team, and casually tossed out an order.

"Treat him just enough, then dump him somewhere."

If he died, so be it. Even if he recovered, he would not be able to properly use even half of the skill he currently possessed.

Lee Jungryong had no interest in collecting spent batteries. He already had countless others. All he had to do was replace this one.

Still, he was useful at the end.

Through Park Jihoon, Lee Jungryong had confirmed the extent of Jin Taekyung's ruthlessness.

Once blood had been drawn, he should have killed him. If Lee Jungryong himself had been in that position, he would have done so without fail.

You couldn't take that one step.

What did it matter if he cut off both arms and carved the man's body to pieces? As long as his enemy still drew breath, it wasn't complete revenge.

It was nothing more than venting his anger.

That half-measure will come back to poison you someday.

[1518] Two hundred meters is about 660 ft.

Lee Jungryong let out a derisive chuckle and climbed into the waiting car.

Chapter 286

In the early hours of that morning, a short post appeared on a popular forum frequented by Hunters.

> Guys, I had a weird dream. Can someone interpret it for me?
>
> I can't reveal the specifics, but I'm a member of the Security Team of a major Guild with some clout. Anyway, that part isn't important.
>
> I was working as usual when I nodded off for a moment. Then Lord Fuck appeared in my dream.
>
> My senior said some weird guy kept hanging around, so we went to catch him together. (My senior's a traitorous bastard. I think his real name is Yamamoto, but he's hiding it.) Anyway, the weird guy turned out to be Lord Fuck.
>
> But that's all I remember clearly. After that, my senior did yutori[1519], and I did irasshaimase.[1520]

> ㄴ **Best comment:** Before we interpret the dream, can someone translate this post? I have no idea what the hell this guy is talking about.
>
> ㄴ Same.
>
> ㄴ Forget everything else. What are "yutori"[1521] and "irasshaimase"[1522]? There's no way to figure out the context.
>
> ㄴ Why is his senior a traitor? Did he buy Heattech from Uniqlo?
>
> ㄴ **OP:** Because he keeps using Japanese in this climate. He's always saying stuff like yutori[1523] and gensei.[1524]
>
> ㄴ But you said you did irasshaimase.[1525]
>
> ㄴ **OP:** Yeah.
>
> ㄴ What a lunatic. "Yeah," my ass. LOL.
>
> ㄴ I can smell the problem child from here. Poor senior.

[1519] *Yutori* is Japanese for leeway or flexibility. The Korean post uses the Japanese word without saying what the senior actually did.

[1520] *Irasshaimase* is a Japanese greeting used to welcome customers into a shop.

[1521] *Yutori* is Japanese for leeway or flexibility. The Korean post uses the Japanese word without saying what the senior actually did.

[1522] *Irasshaimase* is a Japanese greeting used to welcome customers into a shop.

[1523] *Yutori* is Japanese for leeway or flexibility. The Korean post uses the Japanese word without saying what the senior actually did.

[1524] *Gensei* is a Japanese-derived term used in Korean for interference or keeping someone in check.

[1525] *Irasshaimase* is a Japanese greeting used to welcome customers into a shop.

> ㄴ **OP:** But when I told my senior about the dream, he said he'd had a similar one. Lord Fuck beat up a hundred of our Guild members and went toe-to-toe with Ares Guild's Vice Guild Master.
>
> ㄴ I want to beat the OP's ass.
>
> ㄴ **OP:** I'm serious;;; Then he started yelling at me because his phone was gone;; He was probably pissed because it was the latest-model AdultPhone.[1526]
>
> ㄴ Hello. I'm a practicing shaman. I sense an unusual energy from your post. Could you tell me more about it?
>
> ㄴ **OP:** Whoa, are you really a shaman?
>
> ㄴ No. I'm lying.
>
> ㄴ **OP:** Whoa. Are you a crazy bastard?

The post was deleted less than ten minutes later.

The people who had seen it didn't give much thought to one attention-seeking lunatic disappearing, and no one suspected that Ares Guild had intervened in the whole affair.

Well, no one except me.

They must have tampered with everyone's memories using mental magic.

It was obviously illegal, but expecting people who raised Black Hunters to care about the law would have been even more ridiculous.

Judging by the comment about the AdultPhone[1527] disappearing, it seemed they had thoroughly checked everyone's phones as well.

That was decisive evidence.

My personal cameraman had bolted outside the moment Park Tae Seop and Park Jihoon appeared, only to fall straight into Ares Guild's hands.

Not that I was particularly disappointed. They had searched me before letting me leave the building anyway. They even checked my shared cloud folder before returning my phone.

They had also been considerate enough to add a warning.

"Just in case you're hiding anything, delete it now. If we catch you concealing something, it won't be pleasant."

I was already in a foul mood because they had found the porn on my phone, and the guy's tone was beyond obnoxious.

If the situation had been any different, I would have given him a good one.

I memorized your face, you square-headed bastard.

[1526] *AdultPhone* is a Korean pun on "iPhone": *ai* can mean "child," so the post jokingly replaces "child phone" with "adult phone."

[1527] *AdultPhone* is a Korean pun on "iPhone": *ai* can mean "child," so the post jokingly replaces "child phone" with "adult phone."

He had an angular face and a crew cut. He had been put in charge of the cleanup, and everyone else kept calling him “Team Leader,” so he was probably Lee Jungryong’s right-hand man.

Qi Sense had revealed his name as Go Jun. His skill was part of the reason I’d bothered to find out.

That bastard seemed to have learned something resembling martial arts, too.

Once suspicion took root, I could see things more clearly than before.

Every Ares Guild member Lee Jungryong had left behind was exceptional. Any one of them could easily take down two ordinary A-rank Hunters alone.

But the impression Go Jun had given me was… honestly, enough to surprise even me.

His obnoxious manner came from confidence in his own ability.

How did Lee Jungryong train people like this?

Could it really be martial arts? Or perhaps a martial art developed independently within Ares Guild.

One question led to another.

I was mulling all this over when a nurse shouted from the hallway.

“Mr. Lee! Patient Im Hyeokjun is conscious!”

I sprang to my feet.

Im Hyeokjun. Im Kkeokjeong’s real name, though hardly anyone ever used it.

After three long days, he had finally regained consciousness.

“Darling! Jun’s dad!”

“Daddy!”

I forced myself to resist the urge to throw open the door to his hospital room. This was time for his family.

The sobs of a wife and children reunited with their husband and father after three days of unconsciousness drifted through the crack around the door.

Only after a wave of weeping had swept through the room and quite some time had passed did our turn finally come.

“Oh, you’re all here?”

Damn it. My throat closed up at his very first words.

Im Kkeokjeong spread his arms with a bright smile, then scrunched up his nose.

“Ugh.”

“Your arm! Be careful with your arm!”

“I thought it would be fine, but it aches a little when I move it.”

“They reattached a severed arm. Did you think it would be fine right away? What are you, a transforming robot?”

Song Song scolded him while casting a healing spell. Once the pain subsided, Im Kkeokjeong’s expression relaxed considerably.

“Thank you, Miss Song.”

“If you’re grateful, please be careful. Didn’t you hear the healer? You need to rest and avoid overexerting yourself for at least two weeks.”

“And thank you for saying that, too.”

“Uncle!”

“Ow, there go my eardrums.”

I never would have imagined how happy it could make me to see him laughing heartily like a bandit.

After letting out the same boisterous laugh as before, Im Kkeokjeong turned to the others.

“Hyung[1528] Kim—no, Guild Master. Thank you so much. The kids’ mother told me how well you looked after me while I was unconscious.”

Butler Kim shook his head slightly.

“There’s no need to thank me. It was only natural. When one of our Guild members suffers something like this, of course we step up.”

“I heard you spent quite a lot of money, too…”

A famous healer had been brought in to treat Im Kkeokjeong, and high-grade potions that casually cost hundreds of millions of won[1529] per bottle had been poured into him without restraint.

It might have been the same in the past, but this was a world where even a human life had a price. Who would go this far for a D-rank Hunter with nothing to his name but years of experience?

Butler Kim chuckled softly at the emotion thickening Im Kkeokjeong’s voice.

“If you really must thank someone, thank the man footing the bill. I’m just the figurehead, so leave me out of it.”

At those words, Im Kkeokjeong’s gaze slowly shifted toward the man footing the bill.

“Team Leader Choi.”

His voice burned as though it carried Scorching Yang Qi. Before Im Kkeokjeong could continue, Team Leader Choi cut him off.

“This wasn’t your fault, Mr. Im. It happened because our Guild was looked down on. I failed to prevent it, so if anyone owes an apology, it’s me.”

[1528] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[1529] Hundreds of millions of won per bottle means roughly 100 million to under 1 billion won: about $71,000–$710,000, or €65,000–€650,000, at the project rates.

“Team Leader Choi!”

Im Kkeokjeong was the sort of man who could make a hardened criminal look like a model prisoner simply by standing beside one, and now tears brimmed in his eyes.

When he reached out to embrace him, Team Leader Choi flinched and stepped back.

“B-be careful with your arm.”

“It’s fine. I just want to hug you once.”

“…I’d like to pass that glorious opportunity on to the last person.”

It didn’t seem like much of an honor, but in the end, my turn came.

“…”

“…”

Silence fell.

There was something I had desperately wanted to say to Im Kkeokjeong once he woke up, but now that I was standing face-to-face with him, my mouth clamped shut like a clam.

Im Kkeokjeong broke the silence first.

“What do you think?”

“About what?”

“My wife and kids. Pretty, right?”

His out-of-nowhere bragging about his family drew a quiet laugh from me.

“Yes. They are.”

“Your sister-in-law is quite the beauty.”

“I’ll give you that. Did you imprison or threaten her?”

“There’s no tree that won’t fall after ten chops. Remember that. I succeeded on the forty-seventh.”

“You just said every tree falls after ten chops.”

Im Kkeokjeong snickered.

“Turns out there are some that won’t. Ten chops didn’t even make a dent.”

“It’s a miracle you weren’t booked as a suspect.”

“You idiot. If I’d given up back then, do you think I could have gotten a beauty like that?”

Im Kkeokjeong’s wife, her face swollen from crying, covered it with one hand and waved the other dismissively.

His two children, both still in elementary school, stared at me with bright, curious eyes as though they had never cried at all.

“Daddy, who is he?”

“Who is he? Who?”

Im Kkeokjeong pulled the clinging children into his arms and answered.

“He’s your uncle. Uncle Taekyung.”

“Uncle Taekyung?”

“Yeah. I’ve told you about him before, right? The handsome, strong uncle.”

So he had told his family about me.

Warmth spread from somewhere deep in my chest. The children’s eyes sparkled even more brightly as they looked at me.

Children were cute and beautiful by nature, but these sisters could have been child actors. So this was the victory of maternal genes.

“Wow! You’re Uncle Taekyung?”

“Nice ta meet you!”

A fond smile spread across my face.

I patted both girls on the head and said to Im Kkeokjeong, “They’re adorable. So innocent.”

“Obviously. Get married and have a daughter yourself. Then you’ll understand why people call men doting dads.[1530]”

I’d been nicknamed a doting dad[1531] in high school, too. Of course, I hadn’t had a daughter.

In any case, the sight of this close-knit family of four made my heart swell.

Im Kkeokjeong raised his arm stiffly and embraced me. His hand, far weaker than before, patted my back.

Tap. Tap.

“Thank you. I’m always grateful.”

The moment I heard those words, my resolve hardened around a decision I had been carrying all this time.

I can’t make the same mistake again.

I repeated the words to myself and hugged Im Kkeokjeong tightly.

Today, one man had returned to his family and friends.

An hour later, only five members of the Peace Guild remained in the hospital room, including Im Kkeokjeong and me.

Im Kkeokjeong’s wife wanted her husband to rest, but his resolve was firm.

“I almost left my beloved wife and kids behind. I need to hear it now. Everything that happened, without leaving out a single detail.”

[1530] The Korean term for a doting dad is *ttal-babo*, literally “daughter fool.” *Ttal* also appears in slang for masturbation, giving Taekyung’s high-school nickname a second meaning.

[1531] The Korean term for a doting dad is *ttal-babo*, literally “daughter fool.” *Ttal* also appears in slang for masturbation, giving Taekyung’s high-school nickname a second meaning.

The good-natured man who had always been softhearted and full of laughter had gained firm resolve and steel in his spine.

By the time he had heard the entire story, Im Kkeokjeong's face was rigid.

"It was Ares Guild?"

"Yes."

"And the Lee Jungryong you mentioned really is that Lee Jungryong?"

"I'm sure."

"…Hah."

A groanlike sigh escaped him.

We had followed the tail called Black Hunter and found Myeongdong Guild. When we stepped on Myeongdong Guild's torso, the head that emerged was Ares Guild.

The problem was that this was no ordinary head.

"We followed a snake's tail and found a dragon's head."

As I said that, I cast a sidelong glance at Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim. Both of them wore their usual calm expressions.

But I had seen it clearly.

Before Im Kkeokjeong regained consciousness, when they first heard the name Ares Guild, a storm had raged in the eyes of both men.

There's definitely something going on…

I didn't know exactly what. Song Song and I had sensed something strange and questioned them relentlessly, but they had clammed up after briefly saying they would tell us once Im Kkeokjeong woke up.

But now it's time for them to talk.

Perhaps he sensed Song Song's and my gazes. Team Leader Choi was just about to open his mouth when—

Thud. Thud.

All kinds of sounds mingled together in the hospital hallway. But their footsteps were different. They were unusually heavy, with a deep, resonant echo.

And there was qi.

"They're coming."

At my words, everyone rose from their seats one after another.

Sure enough, the footsteps stopped in front of our hospital room.

Knock, knock.

The door opened, revealing a face I had seen only half a day ago.

Go Jun?

Wait. If that bastard was here, then could it be…?

The thought broke off. Go Jun's face vanished from view as another man strode into the hospital room.

He was nearing seventy, yet his youthful appearance made him look like a man in his forties. He possessed a leader’s charisma and a natural air of intimidation.

Lee Jungryong.

His gaze swept over us before stopping dead on one person. The corner of his mouth lifted slightly.

“You’ve grown a lot.”

Team Leader Choi’s gaze sank deeply as he looked at Lee Jungryong.

Chapter 287

Me, Im Kkeokjeong, Song Song, and Butler Kim.

Yet the moment Lee Jungryong entered the hospital room, his gaze settled on one person alone.

Team Leader Choi.

“You’ve grown a lot.”

“…!”

The moment I heard Lee Jungryong’s first words, I felt as though someone had struck me in the back of the head with a sledgehammer.

So this was what Team Leader Choi had been hiding.

Their relationship was clearly more than that of an ordinary superior and subordinate at work.

As far as I know, Team Leader Choi was with Ares Guild for only three or four years.

Even by the most conservative estimate, he must have met Lee Jungryong in his early to mid-twenties. “You’ve grown a lot” wasn’t something you said to a man like that.

It was the sort of thing you heard from your parents’ friends or relatives during the holidays.

“It’s been a long time, Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong.”

The stiff title and formal tone made Lee Jungryong study Team Leader Choi with interest.

“Vice Guild Master? When you were young, you used to call me Grandpa.”

Grandpa?

That was the second shock. For a moment, I wondered if perhaps… but quickly dismissed the thought.

It was simply what Team Leader Choi had called him as a child. Lee Jungryong couldn’t actually be his grandfather.

Still, they’ve clearly had a close relationship since Team Leader Choi was young.

That alone made Team Leader Choi’s relationship with Lee Jungryong anything but ordinary.

While everyone else stood stunned, only two people remained composed: Butler Kim and Team Leader Choi, who answered calmly.

“That was twenty years ago.”

“Time is frightening. Who would have thought that sweet little boy would turn out like this?”

“The older I got, the more I began to see the things that had once been invisible to me.”

“I received a report that you resigned last year. Come to think of it, I never saw your face even once after you joined the Guild. I must admit, I found that rather disappointing.”

Despite his words, he didn’t look disappointed in the slightest. Neither did Team Leader Choi.

“I felt the same way. If you hadn’t immediately transferred me overseas and barred me from even setting foot in headquarters, we might have seen each other more often.”

“Why? Didn’t you like the overseas branch?”

“I felt it wasn’t where I belonged. That’s all.”

“Not where you belonged…”

“Wasn’t that exactly what you wanted, Vice Guild Master?”

“Me?”

Lee Jungryong let out a quiet laugh.

“So you built yourself a new nest? Even going so far as to borrow someone else’s name?”

“I’m sorry to interrupt.”

Butler Kim, who had remained silent until then, suddenly spoke. His voice was as calm as ever.

“But the Young Master and I are hardly strangers.”

“Oh, who might this be?”

Lee Jungryong widened his eyes in feigned surprise.

The reaction was clearly exaggerated. If he knew Team Leader Choi, there was no way he wouldn’t know Butler Kim, the person closest to him.

“Kim Hwajong? It is Hwajong, isn’t it?”

“It’s been a long time, Senior.”

Butler Kim didn’t refuse Lee Jungryong’s outstretched hand. The two men shook hands, each wearing a faint smile.

Informal speech? And Senior?

Whatever their exact relationship was, they seemed much closer than I’d expected.

“It was a good thing I came in person. The last time we met was… about twenty years ago, wasn’t it?”

“Eighteen years, to be precise. *Ship-pal* years.”[1532]

Was it just my imagination, or had he put extra force into those particular words?

I glanced to the side. Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong looked as though they had seen a ghost.

[1532] *Ship-pal*, meaning “eighteen” in Korean, sounds similar to *ssibal*, a strong profanity.

Ah. So it wasn't my imagination.

Close, my ass. I must have been blind.

I take it back. Butler Kim didn't merely dislike Lee Jungryong.

He fucking hated him. Enough to wish he had died.

Butler Kim was a mage, so he wasn't holding an actual knife, but his tongue was every bit as sharp as a blade.

At his vicious words, Go Jun, who had been standing behind Lee Jungryong like an iron tower, took a step forward.

"Watch your mouth."

"Watch my mouth?"

"He is not someone you may address so carelessly."

Butler Kim gave Go Jun an odd look.

"You seem highly skilled at a glance, Hunter. What is your name?"

"I'm Go Jun, head of the Vice Guild Master's security."

"I see. Team Leader Seok."

Butler Kim's distinctive low voice continued smoothly.

"If you've said everything you have to say, shut your mouth and get back behind him. This isn't a place for the likes of you to interfere."

"…!"

Go Jun's already expressionless face stiffened.

Just as veins began to bulge on his forehead, Lee Jungryong burst into hearty laughter and motioned him back.

"I thought age might have mellowed you, but… your temper hasn't changed at all. This is the Kim Hwajong I remember."

"When it comes to a foul temper, you still have me beat by a mile, Senior. Wouldn't you agree?"

Team Leader Choi cut in coldly.

"Enough of this pointless conversation. Get to the matter at hand."

How many people in Korea—or the entire world—could speak to Lee Jungryong that way?

Im Kkeokjeong and Song Song gaped at the stormy exchange.

Even I was inwardly astonished by Butler Kim's behavior, despite having personally witnessed him treat Im Chunsoo, the Guild Master of Sangdong Guild, like a dog several months ago.

What on earth happened between them?

It wasn't just Team Leader Choi. Even Butler Kim was acting completely unlike his usual self.

“One of you is young and impatient, while the other still hasn’t shed the temper of his youth. Well, I suppose there’s no harm in getting to the point. Though it is a little disappointing, considering I came here as an invited guest.”

“Did you just call this an invitation?”

“You’re mistaken. No one here would invite you, Vice Guild Master.”

“Think carefully. Surely there’s at least one person who did?”

Lee Jungryong had been watching the two of them with amusement. Then he suddenly turned toward me.

“That fellow.”

Silence descended over the room.

With everyone’s eyes on me, I thought for a moment before carefully opening my mouth.

“What kind of bullshit is that?”

The instant I finished speaking, Go Jun let out a low growl. He looked ready to charge like a hunting dog if Lee Jungryong hadn’t shaken his head.

After restraining Go Jun, Lee Jungryong spoke to me.

“Didn’t you say so yourself? That I should come in person and apologize to the victim.”

“Oh.”

I had definitely said that.

To Park Jihoon and Park Tae Seop.

“You look as though you never expected me to come.”

“To be honest, I didn’t. What are you plotting by coming all the way here?”

“You have a tendency to say whatever comes to mind without thinking it through. Since I accepted your invitation, shouldn’t you begin by thanking me?”

Thank him?

I let out a hollow laugh. The rest of his words were so absurd that they weren’t even worth answering.

“Your mouth may be crooked, but at least speak straight. It wasn’t an invitation. It was a demand. A demand for an apology.”

“No. If coming here had not been my own decision, could you—or the Peace Guild, for that matter—have made me move even a single step?”

“That’s…”

“Didn’t you think so yourself? You never truly expected me to come.”

It felt as though someone had dumped a bucket of cold water over me. The words caught in my throat.

Everything he said was true.

Though my heart had cried out for anger and revenge, I had never expected Lee Jungryong to come. Even in the midst of that rage, my mind had coldly compromised with reality.

Lee Jungryong, the man who effectively ruled Ares Guild, was still a giant I couldn't force to his knees with my current strength.

"A demand is the right of the strong. Words spoken by the weak to the strong can never be demands. They are always requests—or invitations."

"…!"

"That's why I came in response to an invitation. Whatever leverage you think you have over me, that fact will not change. I am Lee Jungryong. I am Ares Guild, and Ares Guild is me."

His voice was quiet, but it carried weight. Everyone in the Peace Guild, myself included, was left speechless.

At least one thing was clear.

Lee Jungryong hadn't come here to apologize.

Having driven the overwhelming difference in our power into our minds, he continued with a satisfied smile.

"And this is no way to treat a guest who came to visit a patient. Especially one who brought a gift for him. Isn't that right, Team Leader Seok?"

"That is correct, Vice Guild Master."

Go Jun answered like a robot and knocked on the door. A Hunter from the security team who had been waiting outside entered and placed what he was carrying on the table.

A vase filled with hundreds of flowers.

And an envelope.

"Compensation money. If the amount isn't enough, tell me. I'll give you as much as you need."

My gaze remained fixed on the flowers. They were beautiful and white. I had never been particularly fond of flowers, but I had never disliked them, either.

Yet this was the first time in my life that receiving flowers as a gift had made me feel disgusted.

Lilies as a hospital-visit gift.[1533]

My dormant anger began crawling back up from the depths.

I rubbed the stiff, tingling back of my neck and muttered,

"What a fucking old bastard…"

This time, even Go Jun couldn't restrain himself.

With a roar, he charged. His fist slammed into my lower jaw at blinding speed.

[1533] White lilies are associated with funerals and mourning, making them an unsettling gift for a hospital patient.

Crack!

Blood sprayed with a chilling sound.

I frowned and slowly turned my tilted head. The taste of sticky, salty blood spread through my mouth.

“Damn it. I bit my tongue.”

Go Jun’s eyes widened. He looked back and forth between his fist and me as though he couldn’t believe what he was seeing.

“How?”

“I’m pretty tough. I drank a lot of milk when I was young.”

“I definitely imbued it with mana…”

If it had been fully materialized Fist Energy, I wouldn’t still be standing here like this.

Of course, if that had been the case, I wouldn’t have deliberately let him hit me, either.

I flashed him a grin.

“You should have used everything you had. Enough to finish me in one blow.”

Whoosh!

“Hup!”

Go Jun sucked in a short breath and reached out to knock my arm aside. He was so fast that an ordinary A-rank Hunter couldn’t even compare.

His hand curved like a hook as it snapped toward my wrist.

This really is a grappling technique.

Remembering the surprise I had felt while fighting Park Jihoon, I smoothly twisted my wrist.

Slip.

His hand clawed through empty air. I wound around his wrist, locked it in place, and put my weight into a stomp that crashed down onto the top of his foot.

Crack!

“Urgh!”

The weight of a thousand geun[1534] crushed Go Jun’s instep and drove it deep into the solid concrete. Groaning in pain, he raised his arm to shield his face.

But…

“You think that’ll do?”

One thing was certain.

I hadn’t avoided his blow.

Go Jun hadn’t been able to avoid mine.

Crunch!

[1534] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is 600 kg (about 1,320 lb).

My fist struck the exact center of his face, breaking his nose in one blow and caving in the flesh beneath it.

His mouth gaped open, spraying blood and white teeth.

Clatter. Thud.

“Fucking bastard. Who said you could throw the first punch?”

“…!”

It all happened in an instant. Everyone in the hospital room was shocked, but one person’s reaction stood out in particular.

“You bastard…”

The voice that had remained relaxed throughout trembled faintly. Ripples spread through Lee Jungryong’s eyes.

I quickly spoke first, before things could get worse.

“For the record, that was self-defense.”

But the words I heard next were something I could never have anticipated.

“What is your relationship with my older brother?”

“Excuse me? Who?”

“The person who taught you that.”

“If you mean that…”

My eyes widened.

Was this old man talking about martial arts?

But Lee Jungryong was no longer listening to me. His gaze had turned cold and heavy as he stared at Team Leader Choi.

“Did Soyeong have another man?”

I didn’t know who Soyeong was.

But to someone else, that name was apparently a dragon’s reverse scale—a point that must never be touched.

Team Leader Choi clenched his fists, and blue flames blazed in Butler Kim’s eyes.

“Senior. Do you want to die?”

“Answer me.”

“You bastard! Lee Jungryong!”

“Now.”

That was when Team Leader Choi’s tightly sealed lips finally parted.

“You know better than I do what kind of relationship those two had.”

“Then that bastard…”

“You must have already investigated Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Are you saying all of it is true?”

“It is exactly as you know it. There isn’t a single lie.”

Lee Jungryong’s eyes trembled.

After looking back and forth between Team Leader Choi and me, he finally turned away. The door opened as though someone had been waiting for the signal, but he came to an abrupt stop before leaving.

He tossed out a single sentence.

“I’ll send someone soon. Once the negotiations are over, hand over the people you’re holding.”

Click.

The door closed behind the last person to leave—the security team Hunter carrying Go Jun on his back.

It felt as though a storm had just swept through the room.

I turned toward Team Leader Choi, who was silently staring at the tightly closed door.

“Who is Soyeong?”

“She was my mother.”

“…What?”

“The mother who gave birth to me and raised me. She passed away a long time ago.”

My mouth fell open despite myself.

What the hell is wrong with that old man?

Lee Jungryong had asked Team Leader Choi whether his late mother had cheated while she was alive—her own son, no less.

“Crazy. Why would he—ah, never mind. You don’t have to answer.”

“Vice Guild Master Lee must have been quite shaken. Even I didn’t expect him to ask so directly.”

To hell with whether he was shaken.

I frantically waved my hand.

“Team Leader, really, it’s fine. You don’t have to tell me.”

“Sometimes I wonder what it would have been like if my mother had been born as someone other than Cheon Taemin’s daughter.”

“All right, that’s enough…”

My body abruptly froze.

What did he just say?

Although I couldn’t move an inch, my mind repeated those three syllables faster than ever.

Cheon Taemin. Cheon Taemin. Cheon Taemin…

“Did you just say Cheon Taemin?”

“If my pronunciation wasn’t incorrect, then you heard me correctly.”

“Could it be… the Cheon Taemin I know?”

"Yes."

Team Leader Choi nodded and continued.

"He is my maternal grandfather."

For a moment, my vision spun and my legs wobbled.

Cheon Taemin. He said Cheon Taemin.

I had once harbored doubts about Team Leader Choi's identity.

A man in his twenties with seemingly limitless ability, whom an A-rank mage known as a hidden hero of the Great Cataclysm called Young Master.

Now I finally understood how all of that had been possible.

It was because his maternal grandfather was Cheon Taemin.

Humanity's great hero. The world's greatest Hunter…

Among all the words used to describe Cheon Taemin, the title "Guild Master of Ares Guild" was only one small piece.

The name of the largest piece was an immortal achievement no one else could ever attain.

The man who killed the Demon King. The Slayer.

That Cheon Taemin's maternal grandson was standing before me.

Chapter 288

In the back seat of the spacious limousine, Lee Jungryong held Go Jun's arm and sent his mana flowing into it.

Go Jun's limp body twitched, then strength returned to it.

He opened his eyes with difficulty, letting out a faint groan. Lee Jungryong asked, "Are you conscious?"

"…I'm sorry. I should have kept him occupied longer."

Go Jun lowered his head, his face rigid.

His earlier attack on Jin Taekyung had not been impulsive.

Go Jun was Lee Jungryong's Disciple and Head of Security. A man with his exceptional composure and self-control would never have done such a thing unless ordered by the master he respected above all others.

Jin Taekyung. I need to see what that bastard is truly capable of.

What would you have me do?

"I'll buy as much time as I can. Make him show everything he has."

I never liked the bastard. It seems I'll finally get to teach him a proper lesson.

He should not have said that last part.

After speaking so boldly, he had failed to withstand even a single blow. He could not bring himself to face Lee Jungryong.

"You exchanged blows with him yourself, so you must have felt it. Tell me exactly how strong he is. Leave nothing out."

It did not take Go Jun long to answer.

"He's strong."

Jin Taekyung had stormed Myeongdong Guild alone. Go Jun had known from the start that he was not someone to take lightly.

But even after taking a mana-infused punch squarely, Taekyung had not fallen—or even retreated a single step. Go Jun had never imagined anyone could possess such absurd toughness.

"I struck him cleanly on the jaw, but he was harder than rebar. I've never seen anyone like him."

Taekyung had not been wearing armor or protected by defensive magic. Go Jun could not understand how he had emerged so completely unscathed.

The bigger problem was that Jin Taekyung did not merely possess exceptional toughness.

"His strength and speed both surpassed mine."

"What if you had gone all-out from the beginning, Team Leader Seok?"

After a brief hesitation, Go Jun answered stiffly.

"…It would still have been difficult."

He remembered Taekyung's lightning-fast hands.

Before he knew what was happening, his arm had been trapped and his foot driven deep into the ground. He had hastily raised his arm to shield his face, but the fist behind it had struck with such monstrous force that it smashed straight through his guard and into his face.

"I don't know how, but Jin Taekyung has extensive combat experience. He's on an entirely different level from ordinary Hunters who only fight monsters."

"And?"

"Pardon?"

"There's something you haven't said yet, isn't there?"

"…"

"I believe I told you to leave nothing out."

The moment Go Jun met Lee Jungryong's gaze, he understood.

Lee Jungryong had reached the same conclusion.

"You already suspected it."

"Yes. Today, that suspicion became certainty."

"You mean…"

Lee Jungryong's voice sank low.

"There's no doubt about it. Jin Taekyung has learned a mana cultivation method."

"…!"

A mana cultivation method.

A faint ripple disturbed Go Jun's unwavering gaze. That was how shocking Lee Jungryong's words were.

"An insignificant F-rank Hunter became this strong in barely half a year. People keep babbling about reawakening and faulty measuring devices, but that's nothing more than ignorant nonsense."

Go Jun muttered as if groaning.

"But how…? Aren't mana cultivation methods among the most closely guarded secrets?"

"Top secret? That phrase is meaningless. As long as someone knows a secret, it can never be absolute."

"Could Team Leader Choi be responsible?"

Lee Jungryong shook his head.

"That boy Minwoo never learned a mana cultivation method. Neither did Kim Hwajong, who has remained by his side since childhood."

"Isn't it something no one knows about? If the Guild Master…"

"Who?"

Go Jun's words died in his throat. He froze.

The moment he met Lee Jungryong's dark, sunken gaze, he realized he had said something he should not have.

"I believe I told you never to utter a word about my older brother."

"I-I'm sorry. It was a slip of the tongue…"

Go Jun's voice quivered like a wounded bird.

The revelation that Taekyung had learned a mana cultivation method had rattled him enough to break an unspoken taboo. Cheon Taemin, the Guild Master of Ares Guild, was someone who must never be mentioned.

Thud!

Both of Go Jun's knees struck the floor. He bowed his head deeply.

"Please forgive me, Vice Guild Master."

"Forgive you? These things happen."

"…"

"Get up."

Even after carefully lifting his knees from the floor and sitting back down, Go Jun could not look Lee Jungryong straight in the eye.

He had spent years at Lee Jungryong's side and had seen and learned many things.

To Go Jun, Lee Jungryong inspired both respect and fear.

Faint fear now colored the face that was ordinarily as expressionless as a machine.

"Team Leader Seok."

Lee Jungryong broke the suffocating silence.

Go Jun lowered his head even further.

"Yes, Vice Guild Master. Please speak."

"You're going to be very busy from now on. If you run your mouth as carelessly as you did today, you'll put me in a very difficult position."

"I'll remember that. I'll never forget it."

"Strengthen our surveillance of the Peace Guild. Find out whether they have anyone useful, too."

Go Jun cautiously raised his head.

"Are you planning to expand the security team?"

"Yes. We can't go on like this. We must prepare for any eventuality."

"Yes. I'll put it into action as soon as we return to the Guild."

"And… keep a close watch on the executives' movements. Include the status of our overseas branches."

"I'll carry it out without a single omission."

Lee Jungryong's position within Ares Guild was already secure.

But not everyone followed him as blindly as Go Jun did.

There were always those who harbored discontent, and they watched Lee Jungryong's every move with suspicion.

The security team, on the other hand, was little more than Lee Jungryong's private army.

Paid enormous salaries and taught mana cultivation methods, its members offered their absolute loyalty to one man alone: Lee Jungryong.

Yes. Things have been too peaceful for too long.

Lee Jungryong turned toward the window. Beyond the spotless glass, the Han River stretched wide into the distance.

Only thirty-some years ago, its waters had been filled with the corpses of humans and monsters. Now they were clear and clean, as though nothing had ever happened.

Older brother. The world has changed so much.

Lee Jungryong did not speak the thought aloud.

His gaze was already retracing the distant past. Burning cities and dying people. Monster legions charging forward, overturning heaven and earth…

And amid that hellscape, one man had shone alone.

Do not take so much as a single step out from behind me.

Lee Jungryong had been thirty then, filled with cynicism toward the world. The moment he met that man, he was captivated.

Though they did not share a single drop of blood, Lee Jungryong regarded him as an older brother and always looked up to him with both respect and fear.

Even now, past the age of sixty, those memories and emotions remained vivid.

Lee Jungryong was staring silently out the window, lost in thought, when Go Jun's voice brought him back.

"We've arrived."

At the same moment, the limousine door slid open. Before them stood a skyscraper tall enough to pierce the clouds, surrounded by a forest of buildings like guards protecting a king.

Dozens of waiting Hunters bowed to him. The lapels of their suits bore the emblem of Ares Guild.

"Welcome, Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong!"

Their shout was perfectly synchronized, as though measured with a ruler.

A faint smile on his lips, the man in power stepped onto the red carpet.

This was a world where even white-haired old men wore wireless earbuds and watched iTube.

Whenever snow fell and icy roads formed, nursing homes shut down, while Old Man Kim and Granny Park chatted through a voice-chat app and played online Go-Stop.[1535]

If magic was a mysterious realm of unknowable origins, the internet was the culmination of twenty-first-century civilization.

With a few clicks and keystrokes, anyone could learn what was happening anywhere in the world as easily as reading the palm of their hand.

In a world like this, information about the most famous person among billions was even easier to find.

Tap. Tap-tap.

Cheon Taemin.

His name completed itself after I typed only the initial consonants.[1536] It even ranked higher in searches than heaven.

People were more interested in the man who had stopped them from nearly going to heaven than in heaven itself.

I was no different.

Muttering inwardly, I tapped the search result that read “Cheon Taemin—Profile.”

The face I had seen hundreds—no, thousands—of times since elementary school filled my phone screen.

Thick eyebrows and chiseled features. He looked like a handsome Greek god reincarnated.

And…

“He looks like him.”

“Now that I see them side by side, they really do look alike.”

“Whoa. They’re identical.”

They looked alike. So much so that I understood why people said blood would always tell.

Im Kkeokjeong, Song Song, and I stared openmouthed, looking back and forth between the phone and Team Leader Choi.

“Ahem.”

Only when Team Leader Choi finally cleared his throat uncomfortably did we come to our senses.

No, not yet. Come to my senses, my ass.

What the hell is going on?

Things were getting spectacularly insane now, whether in Murim or the modern world.

[1535] Go-Stop is a Korean card game played with *hwatu*, traditional flower cards.

[1536] Written Korean syllables are composed of consonants and vowels. Korean search tools can autocomplete a name from the initial consonants of its syllables.

When Park Jihoon stabbed me in the back and Lee Jungryong appeared out of nowhere, I'd been certain nothing could surprise me anymore…

But this was shock and horror in its purest form.

Not the President's grandson, but Cheon Taemin's.

A president's term lasted five years. Cheon Taemin had no term.

The achievements and Fame attached to his name would remain immortal, passed down through the generations.

He had driven a sword into the Demon King's heart and saved all humanity. What more needed to be said?

Humanity's hero. The world's greatest Hunter, recognized across the globe.

Unprecedented and unmatched. The very definition of both.

Team Leader Choi was Cheon Taemin's only grandson through his daughter.

Cheon Taemin had only one daughter, and there was no information about any other relatives. Team Leader Choi was probably his sole heir.

Good God. Cheon Taemin's heir.

The thought alone gave me goose bumps.

I opened my mouth, my voice trembling.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes, go ahead."

Team Leader Choi answered as though he had been waiting for me to speak. He even looked relieved that the awkward silence had finally been broken.

"If it isn't too rude, may I ask you something?"

"Anything."

"Then can I keep calling you Team Leader Choi?"

"What?"

Team Leader Choi stared at me in disbelief.

"What exactly were you planning to call me instead?"

"Mr. Choi Minwoo. Minwoo hyung.[1537]"

"I refuse."

"There's one more option…"

"Don't say it. I don't want to hear it."

"Please adopt me. I'll call you Dad. I'll be a good son."

Team Leader Choi's face flushed bright red.

If I had actually been his son, he looked ready to strike me from the family register on the spot.

A moment later, he let out a deep sigh.

"…This isn't the time for jokes."

[1537] *Hyung* is a term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"I'm not joking. I mean it."

"Mr. Jin Taekyung!"

Team Leader Choi continued in a low, stern voice.

"Didn't I tell you everything? What kind of situation I'm in?"

"You did. We all heard you."

Im Kkeokjeong and Song Song nodded.

An hour earlier, after Lee Jungryong had left, Team Leader Choi had told us everything while we were still reeling from the shock.

His true identity. Everything that had happened until now. And why he had been forced to act as he had.

"Lee Jungryong is an extremely ambitious man. He considers me a thorn in his side and has always kept me under surveillance. He made me move from one overseas branch to another to prevent me from setting foot in headquarters."

Team Leader Choi said he had been surrounded by watchful eyes.

Lee Jungryong had assigned him to dead-end posts to prevent him from producing any notable results, and even then, he had been transferred to a new posting once a year. They called them overseas branches, but it had been little different from exile.

"Cheon Taemin—no. Did the Ares Guild Master simply stand by and watch?"

"As I said, my maternal grandfather…"

Team Leader Choi bit down hard on his lip.

"He's an extraordinary person. My memories are from when I was a child, but he definitely isn't someone who thinks like an ordinary person."

Butler Kim, who had been standing quietly at attention, added, "He was that way in the past, and he remains so now. I served the old master for many years, but not once did I understand his true intentions."

Was this the dark side of the hero no one knew?

Team Leader Choi sighed and continued.

"Even after I submitted my resignation and left Ares Guild, they must have kept watching me. Later, I founded the Peace Guild… but recruiting even one ordinary mid-rank Hunter proved difficult."

It was something I had not known until hearing his story, but Im Kkeokjeong and I had not been the Peace Guild's first members.

Several high-ranking Hunters had joined before us, only to transfer to other Guilds after receiving generous contract offers out of nowhere. Some had even abruptly gone off the grid before they could sign their contracts.

It was probably Lee Jungryong's doing.

No matter how much money you had, a Guild without Hunters was no Guild at all.

With Ares Guild tightening the screws from every direction, Team Leader Choi had begun searching for people through the Hunter Office.

That was when Im Kkeokjeong and I appeared on his radar.

Fortunately, there had been no significant pressure this time.

Two low-ranked Hunters probably didn't seem worth bothering with.

And that had been Ares Guild's miscalculation.

No one could have imagined that an F-rank Hunter who seemed useful only as a porter would create a storm like this.

"This incident is no different. When I heard that you had encountered Lee Jungryong, Mr. Taekyung, I thought it had happened because of me."

"So?"

"Pardon?"

I vigorously scratched the back of my head.

"So what are you trying to say, Team Leader? You still haven't said it clearly."

"The difference in strength is too great for us to make an enemy of Ares Guild."

"Everyone knows that."

"Things like this will keep happening."

"More detail. Be precise."

Team Leader Choi gritted his teeth.

"I'll terminate your contracts. If you cut ties with the Peace Guild, Ares Guild won't bother any of you."

His voice seethed with emotion. Team Leader Choi closed his eyes and clenched his fists.

I stared at him for a moment, then spoke.

"I don't want to."

"What?"

"I said I don't want to."

"…"

"They're dinosaurs. We're ants. We're weak, so let's back off before we get hurt worse. That's what you're saying, right?"

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Then it's simple."

Team Leader Choi stared at me with wide eyes. I spoke slowly, enunciating every word.

"Let's get stronger."

No.

"I'll make you strong. I will."

Chapter 289

"Pardon?"

Team Leader Choi looked more violently shaken than I had ever seen him before.

Even Butler Kim, who at least looked calm, wasn't much different.

Lingering anger and bewilderment. And questions about what I had said.

I didn't know they could make faces like that.

Whenever I charged ahead without thinking things through, these two always took two calm steps back and handled the fallout.

For once, they seemed human—just like me.

Feeling strangely moved, I opened my mouth.

"The answer is simple. If our enemies are strong, we get stronger too."

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

Team Leader Choi's voice was quiet and steady. He had reined in his initial emotions and returned to his usual composed self.

"This isn't a math problem that can be solved simply because you know the answer. Reaching that answer would require a process more difficult than you can imagine."

"Then we'll be fine. If I tutor you, we should be able to solve it eventually, even if it takes some time. Oh, but let's change the subject. I'm hopeless at math."

"Have you forgotten? Our opponent is Ares Guild. You may not know this, but I do. I know exactly how powerful they are."

"Unfortunately, the Young Master is right."

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim fell silent after that.

One was the maternal grandson of Cheon Taemin, Guild Master of Ares Guild. The other was a core member who had served Cheon Taemin for many years.

Given their positions, they must have seen and experienced a great deal firsthand. Their blood might have been boiling, but their cool heads had already calculated the answer.

But…

"Team Leader Choi."

I looked into his eyes, which already said the matter was settled.

"Do you remember what you said to me before we went to Myeongdong Guild?"

"Of course."

"What did you say back then?"

After a moment's hesitation, Team Leader Choi parted his lips.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung may seem reckless at first glance, but…"

"I always anticipate the worst-case scenario before acting. And?"

“You always bring back the best possible result.”

“You said you trusted me more than you trusted yourself, Team Leader. Did you only say that because it sounded nice?”

“Absolutely not.”

“I may have been a lousy student, but I’m not stupid enough to risk my life on a game with zero chance of winning. This is doable.”

“Doable…”

“If you can’t believe in yourself, believe in me.”

Light seeped into Team Leader Choi’s eyes as he sensed the sincerity behind my words. It was faint, but I knew what it was.

Hope.

Hope was like a spark. It could flare up or die out in an instant. You had to fan it before it went out.

“Since we’re on the subject, let me ask you something. If I leave the Guild now, will you give up too? I suppose shutting down the Guild, retiring, and farming with Butler Kim wouldn’t be so bad. Lee Jungryong might even supply the fertilizer.”

“Hunter Jin Taekyung!”

Ignoring Butler Kim’s attempt to stop me, I continued.

“You said you wanted to build the greatest Guild in the world. If you send me away, send Uncle Kkeokjeong and Song-i away, and let even the new recruits leave, are the two of you planning to fight Ares Guild by yourselves?”

“…”

“Team Leader Choi.”

He remained silent. No answer came.

But the spark in his eyes was still alive.

Before long, a hoarse voice slipped between his lips.

“Ares Guild is an empire. An empire so powerful that even the ten largest Guilds in Korea couldn’t stand against it if they joined forces.”

“Good grief. We’ll have to work hard if we want to catch up with them.”

“I may not know everything about Ares Guild, but I know a great deal. That only makes them seem even more dangerous.”

“It also improves our chances. It means we know our enemy well. Know your enemy and know yourself, and you can fight a hundred battles without disaster. Right?”

“I’ve considered it countless times, but every calculation told me it was impossible.”

“Then run the numbers again.”

“Is it really… possible?”

“Yes.”

“Where exactly did my calculations go wrong? What makes you so confident in your answer?”

He wasn’t asking because he failed to understand.

More than anyone, Team Leader Choi wanted his answer to be wrong. He wanted even the faintest possibility that we could stand against Lee Jungryong.

I was happy to give him the answer he wanted.

“The person talking to you right now.”

“…!”

“The process of your calculations was accurate. Except for one thing.”

I slowly raised a finger and pointed at my chest.

“Me.”

At that moment, Team Leader Choi’s eyes shook. I could feel the spark in them beginning to fade.

Disappointment, not hope, filled the void it left behind.

“You were included in my calculations, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Of course I was. You wouldn’t be the Team Leader Choi I know otherwise.”

Team Leader Choi was a brilliant man. He possessed natural leadership, exceptional judgment, and the drive to act on it.

He had weighed Peace Guild against Ares Guild with a cool head, and I must have been included on Peace Guild’s side of the scale.

“Everything you’ve shown us until now has been astonishing. No, almost miraculous.”

I already knew what words would follow his fading voice.

“But I’m still not enough?”

Team Leader Choi nodded gravely.

“Even excluding Lee Jungryong, an S-rank Hunter, Ares Guild officially has more than a hundred A-rank Hunters. Their mid- and low-rank Hunters are beyond counting.”

The way he emphasized *officially* implied that they had even more strength hidden from the public.

And they still have more than a hundred A-rank Hunters.

I had heard the rumors before, but hearing it directly from Team Leader Choi made the true scale of Ares Guild’s power sink in.

No matter how strong I was, in the end, I was still only one pair of hands. Team Leader Choi’s judgment was cold and clear.

But…

“If that’s how you’re calculating it, you’ll have to run the numbers again.”

“Pardon?”

“The formula is right, but the numbers are wrong. I don’t know what value you assigned to me, but you’ll need to multiply it several times over.”

Team Leader Choi’s eyes widened. So did Butler Kim’s, Im Kkeokjeong’s, and Song Song’s.

Considering everything I had done until now, their reaction was understandable.

I had hunted a Named Monster alone, crushed nearly thirty Black Hunters, and confronted a major Guild like Myeongdong Guild head-on.

Leaving everyone frozen like statues, I fixed my gaze on Team Leader Choi.

“I feel like I’ve told you this repeatedly. I’m a man with more secrets than you think.”

Murim was Murim, and the modern world was the modern world.

There had always been a clear boundary in my mind separating the two. But Lee Jungryong and Ares Guild had erased that line.

If none of this had happened, I probably would have kept my secret for the rest of my life.

Was wanting to live quietly too much to ask?

Perhaps this was the fate that came with the power I had been given. If so, it was time to accept it. I couldn’t keep running forever.

To protect the things precious to me from my enemies, I had to become stronger.

“So, what are you going to do now?”

Team Leader Choi still stared at me in disbelief.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, you never cease to surprise me.”

“Save it. There’ll be plenty more surprises from now on.”

“It will be a dangerous road.”

“I happen to specialize in thorny roads.”

“Far more dangerous than anything you’ve faced until now.”

“Nothing to compare it to, my ass. You just don’t know it. This side is already hell…”

He seemed to have taken my words as a joke.

I watched Team Leader Choi as he finally let out a quiet laugh.

“Team Leader.”

“Yes?”

“Sometimes, it’s okay to be honest.”

The smile vanished from the corners of Team Leader Choi’s mouth. His gaze settled, and his lips pressed into a firm line.

I waited for him to speak. What came next was something I needed to hear directly from him.

Fortunately, I didn’t have to wait long.

“I know this is a presumptuous request, but… would you continue with Peace Guild?”

Yes. That was it.

I grinned and lightly tapped Team Leader Choi on the shoulder. He looked intelligent and cold on the outside, but he was softhearted underneath.

That was why he had tried to send us away despite wanting us to stay. He was afraid we would get hurt.

“Let’s make this work.”

“…Thank you.”

Team Leader Choi offered a fleeting smile before turning toward the others.

Butler Kim, his devoted retainer and someone practically no different from family, spoke first.

“I trust you already know my answer.”

“Thank you, Butler Kim.”

Next was Song Song. When Team Leader Choi asked her the same question he had asked me, she heaved several deep sighs before answering.

“Ares Guild? Ah, the numbers really don’t add up on this one.”

Honestly, that was the most normal reaction. We were openly declaring our intention to make an enemy of Ares Guild. Anyone who welcomed the idea would be strange.

“Double my annual salary. And add hazard pay.”

“…”

Song Song wasn’t normal either.

When I stared at her in disbelief, she shrugged.

“What? Why?”

“No reason. I just thought most people would walk away in a situation like this.”

“Do you want me to leave?”

“Now, now. Absolutely not.”

“Do you know why I transferred from Ares Guild to Peace Guild? Why I followed Team Leader Choi even with everyone trying to keep him down?”

“How would I know?”

“Because Team Leader Choi promised me double my salary.”

“…”

“My goal is to retire at thirty. If I earn as much as I can over the next two years, I’ll be able to live comfortably for the rest of my life.”

She spoke as though it were nothing, but this was only her roundabout way of saying she wanted to stay with us too. Everyone knew the frugal Song Song had already amassed a small fortune.

“And, well, you seem to have a plan too, so I’ll trust you for now. It’s hard to find a superior as capable and handsome as Team Leader Choi.”

And just like that, Song Song’s decision to stay was settled. Everyone’s gaze, including mine, shifted toward the last person.

“Uncle Kkeokjeong.”

He didn’t answer when I called him. Only after a long silence did he finally speak.

“Taekyung, will I be any help?”

“More than enough.”

“Even though I’m only a D-rank Hunter?”

“People associated with D are the real protagonists, after all.[1538] Why not legally change your name while you’re at it? Im D. Kkeokjeong. How does that sound?”

Im Kkeokjeong burst out laughing, then looked Team Leader Choi straight in the eye.

“It wasn’t your fault I got hurt, Team Leader Choi. So don’t blame yourself.”

“No. It was all my fault. Please focus on your recovery and rehabilitation first, then take your time thinking it over. You have a family, Hunter Im.”

“Team Leader Choi.”

“Yes?”

“Do you know what my first thought was when my arms were cut off?”

“Your family?”

He was a woman’s husband and the father of two children.

But Im Kkeokjeong calmly shook his head.

“*Ah, I guess I can’t work as a Hunter anymore.* That was the first thing that came to mind.”

“…”

“I love this work. I spent twenty years going in and out of Gates not merely to earn a living, but because I felt a sense of duty as a Hunter. But…”

Im Kkeokjeong bit down hard on his lip. His gaze remained fixed on his own two arms, wrapped in bandages.

“Can I recover?”

“You can. Absolutely.”

A faint smile spread across Im Kkeokjeong’s lips.

“Then I’m coming too. I can’t abandon a Hunter’s duty over something like this.”

Something churned deep in my chest at the sight.

People dismissed him as a low-rank Hunter in name only, but Im Kkeokjeong was one of the few true Hunters left in this age.

[1538] This alludes to *One Piece*, a Japanese manga in which several major characters have the initial “D.” in their names.

They’re all far too good to stop here.

All right. Strike while the iron was hot.

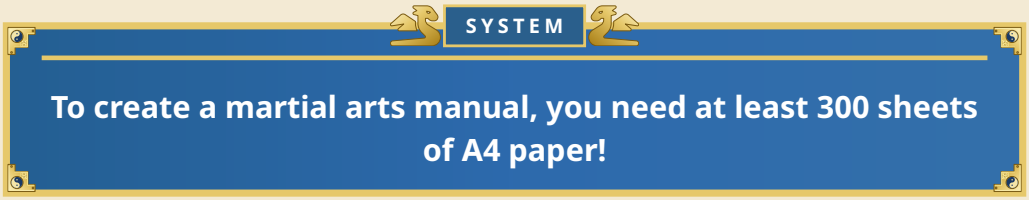
Having made up my mind, I opened my Skill window for the first time in a long while.

There, among the densely packed entries in the holographic window, I found what I wanted.

Yes. This was the beginning.

With firm resolve, I touched the holographic window.

Beep!



“…”

What the fuck.

Chapter 290

SYSTEM

Skill Window
Martial Arts Manual Creation
Grade: None
Restriction: Martial arts at Great Completion
Description: The caster can create manuals only for martial arts they have achieved Great Completion in. A deeper understanding of the martial art may produce better results.
Special Note: Materials are required to create a martial arts manual.

I stared at the Skill information window and thought.

Hold on. When did I get this?

Was it when I achieved Great Completion in the Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique? Or the Jin Family's Spear Technique?

It had been over a year, so my memory was hazy.

I had somehow acquired the Skill, but I had never used it because there had been no opportunity.

No, that wasn't quite right. It wasn't that I had no opportunity. I just never intended to use it.

After returning to the modern world, I had occasionally felt the urge whenever I saw the members of Peace Guild. But every time, I reached the same conclusion.

What kind of trouble would I be asking for if I let martial arts leak out?

Imagine everyone else fighting with bronze weapons when some bastard showed up with a steel sword and started cutting down anyone in his path.

Everyone would envy him, then swarm like a pack of dogs to get their hands on that steel sword.

It wasn't that I didn't trust the members of Peace Guild, but at the time, I believed holding back was the right decision.

But now there's no reason to hesitate.

Crossing blows with Lee Jungryong and his subordinates, Park Jihoon and Go Jun, had taught me that the modern world held secrets I knew nothing about.

Their movements and use of mana were distinctly similar to those of Murim martial artists. If the enemy was armed with steel swords, we needed comparable equipment.

"Hoo…"

I drew a deep breath, sucking a foul stench into my nostrils.

I was currently squatting inside a bathroom stall.

The surroundings were awful, but it was the perfect place to create a martial arts manual without anyone seeing me.

All right. Let's get started.

I spread out the A4 paper and pen I had bought from the hospital convenience store.

Then I muttered inwardly.

Activate Martial Arts Manual Creation.

Beep.

SYSTEM

All materials are ready.
The Martial Arts Manual Creation Skill has been activated.
You can create manuals for martial arts that have achieved Great Completion.
Currently Available: Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, Jin Family's Manoeuvre Technique, Jin Family's Spear Technique
Select the desired martial art.

None of the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts I had learned had reached Great Completion.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan's hereditary martial arts, on the other hand, were stable and reasonably powerful.

Of those, I chose the most fundamental.

Select Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Create a martial arts manual for Jin Family's Cultivation Technique?
Y / N

Yes.

Beep! Beep!

SYSTEM

Intelligence insufficient! Brainpower insufficient!
Teaching is several times harder than learning!
Creating a manual for a Peak-Grade martial art requires at least 100 Intelligence!

"...You bastards. Seriously."

Weeping tears of blood, I opened my Status Window.

The moment I poured my precious points into Intelligence, the hand holding the pen began racing across the A4 paper like lightning.

Scritch-scritch-scritch-scritch!

"Gasp!"

I received two shocks.

The first was the incredible speed. The second was that everything being written was in Chinese.

"..."

Fuck this. I can't work like this.

I began desperately searching for the language settings.

The door slid open.

I entered the hospital room where the Peace Guild members were staying. Everyone had been gathered together talking, but they turned toward me as I came in.

"Where did you go that took so long... Wait, were you in the bathroom?"

Song Song pinched her nose. I answered gloomily.

"How did you know?"

"You reek of shit."

"Is it that bad?"

"Yeah. I thought a giant turd had walked into the room."

"Thanks for the kind words. I feel stronger already."

After spending over an hour inside a stinking bathroom stall, my nose had gone numb.

I answered in a drained voice and handed her the stack of stapled A4 pages.

"Here."

"What's this?"

"A love letter for you. I wrote it while I had diarrhea."

"Blech! Bleegh!"

“What a passionate reaction.”

“Bleeeggh!”

“…”

That wasn’t a reaction. She was genuinely retching.

I had thought there was nothing left between us to salvage, but I still couldn’t help the dull ache in a corner of my heart.

“I loved you…”

“Bleeeggh!”

“Hunter Song Song, are you all right?”

As her retching grew more violent, Butler Kim flew to her side and began patting her back.

Meanwhile, the A4 pages Song Song had been waving like the Taegeukgi[1539] passed into someone else’s hands.

Team Leader Choi read the words on the first page, then let out a quiet laugh as he looked at me.

“Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique? That’s an unusual title for a love letter.”

“What’s written inside is even more unusual.”

“…Pardon?”

“Keep reading.”

Team Leader Choi was quick on the uptake. He immediately straightened and began turning the pages with a solemn expression.

His eyes raced across handwriting so mechanical that it was hard to believe I had written it myself.

Flip. Flip. Flip…

His pace grew faster and faster, and hot breaths escaped between his lips.

After tearing through ten-odd pages in an instant, he jerked his head up. His eyes had widened like saucers.

“This is…!”

Even I was taken aback by his reaction.

He knows what this is?

It might have been called a martial arts manual, but now that I had made it, anyone unfamiliar with the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique could easily have mistaken the manual for a traditional medicine text.

It detailed the locations and functions of the countless acupoints in the human body, along with the pathways used to circulate internal energy.

Song Song would have read a few pages and closed it, but Team Leader Choi’s reaction went far beyond anything I had expected.

[1539] The Taegeukgi is South Korea’s national flag.

“Do you recognize it?”

“Yes. Of course.”

Then a term I had never heard before slipped from his lips.

“This is a Mana Cultivation Method.”

“A mana what?”

“A Mana Cultivation Method!”

Mana Cultivation Method?

What a bizarre name. Whoever had coined it possessed a strange sense of style.

Butler Kim hurried over when he heard Team Leader Choi raise his voice.

“Did you just say Mana Cultivation Method?”

“Yes. Here.”

Butler Kim took the manual from Team Leader Choi and frantically flipped through the pages.

Before long, he reacted much the same way.

“Gasp.”

“What do you think, Butler Kim?”

“There’s no doubt about it. This is definitely a Mana Cultivation Method. But where on earth did this come from?”

The bathroom.

Team Leader Choi raised a finger and pointed at me.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung…”

“Hunter Jin Taekyung?”

Whip! Crack!

Before Team Leader Choi could finish, Butler Kim’s head snapped toward me with a series of violent cracks.

“How does Hunter Jin Taekyung possess a Mana Cultivation Method?”

I answered calmly.

“For starters, I don’t know what a Mana Cultivation Method is. Naturally, this is the first I’ve heard of this being one. By the way, is your neck all right? I think I just heard a bone break…”

“Is that important right now? This little neck of mine can break for all I care.”

“…It sounds pretty important to me.”

What did he mean, it could break? This old man seemed to be getting tougher by the day.

Of course, that only showed how important this was.

So Lee Jungryong learned a Mana Cultivation Method.

The compound term had sounded strange at first, but after repeating it a few times, it began to roll smoothly off my tongue.

It wasn't hard to infer from the name that it referred to an internal cultivation technique used by Hunters.

And that Lee Jungryong and his subordinates had learned precisely such a technique.

"Could you please answer my question?"

"Taekyung, this is extremely important."

Butler Kim and Team Leader Choi looked more grave than ever.

I glanced around as though flustered, then gave them the answer I had prepared in advance.

"Well, my father taught it to me when I was young…"

"Pardon me, but are you referring to your late father?"

Yes.

Team Leader Choi furrowed his brow.

"I understand your late father was an ordinary man."

"That's right."

"Then how did he know a Mana Cultivation Method…?"

"He probably didn't know either. When he taught it to me, he said it was just a health regimen passed down through our family."

"A health regimen?"

"A Mana Cultivation Method passed down through the family…"

As the two stared at me in disbelief, I pointed to the cover.

Four neat characters were printed there in lettering as clean as an office document's font.

Jin Family's Cultivation Technique

Even the name was perfect.

If Shanxi Province had the Jin Family of Taiyuan, then Gyeonggi Province had the Jin Family of Goyang. Simple as that.

If I claimed it was a family heirloom passed down through the generations, they wouldn't have much to argue with.

As expected, they were both briefly rendered speechless. I continued.

"It's a kind of breathing method. My father started teaching it to me when I was young, saying that practicing it would make me healthier. He even made me memorize something called a formula word for word."

"It is similar to a Mana Cultivation Method, but…"

"Could we see the original? The original manual?"

"After my father passed away, everything was so chaotic… I looked for it after we moved, but it was gone."

"Ah…"

"That's unfortunate."

"It is. Fortunately, I memorized every last word."

It was true that something I owned had disappeared. I had merely slipped the nonexistent original manual for the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique into the story.

Perfect destruction of evidence. When they heard that even the original was gone, both of their shoulders sagged.

I'd love to see their faces if they knew this was the original.

The martial arts manuals people imagined all looked more or less the same.

Half-rotted bamboo slips. Ancient books reeking of rat piss.

They could go play jokgu.[1540] I didn't have any of that crap.

I stood the crisp stack of A4 paper upright and slammed a stapler through it. Murim martial artists would have been appalled, but a twenty-first-century martial arts manual deserved to look the part.

"Still, this is extraordinary. A cultivation technique… I never imagined such a thing truly existed."

"I've seen them mentioned a few times in novels and movies. I believe they called them martial arts."

"You are correct, Young Master. In a sense, a Mana Cultivation Method is also a form of martial arts. Look here. It says that you circulate and accumulate qi by circulating your energy, does it not? That follows the same principle as a Mana Cultivation Method…"

Yeah, it is martial arts.

While I fought back the words itching to escape my mouth, Team Leader Choi asked me a question.

"Then, Mr. Jin Taekyung, have you been practicing a Mana Cultivation Method—or rather, the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique—since childhood?"

Yes.

"I'm sorry to put it this way, but its effects seem somewhat less impressive than expected…"

Translated directly, he was asking, *If you had this, why did you spend seven years as an F-rank Hunter?*

A sharp question. Also one I had expected.

I answered without batting an eye.

"As you know, I was quite skilled for an F-rank Hunter. I even received a commendation for graduating at the top of my training center."

[1540] *Jokgu* is Korean foot volleyball. The phrase "go play jokgu" also serves as a minced oath meaning "fuck off."

“Ah, yes. I heard about that. I also know you served as a deputy team leader in your former Guild.”

Granted, it had been a tiny, weak Guild, but F-rank Hunters were treated like punching bags wherever they went—like dog shit on the street.

Unless they were related by blood to the Guild’s leadership, it was extremely rare for an F-rank Hunter to serve as a deputy team leader. That was why my appointment had been a subject of conversation within the Guild for quite some time.

“There was a lot of talk about it. Hunters with higher ranks and more experience than me complained about seniority and grumbled that they should have come first… In the end, I proved myself through sheer ability. And the reason I could do that was the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.”

“Hmm.”

“Looking at it that way, it does seem to have had some effect.”

I knew. This alone wouldn’t be enough to convince them of my past or the effectiveness of the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.

I smiled faintly and looked around. Song Song had finally stopped retching, and even Im Kkeokjeong was watching me with curiosity, waiting for what I would say next.

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“Suppose you roll a snowball the size of your fist down a hill. What happens? Anyone know?”

Song Song snorted at my question.

“Even a kindergartener could answer that.”

“Then answer it.”

“Obviously, it gets bigger as it rolls downhill.”

“Why?”

“Because it picks up the snow piled on the hill.”

“Yeah, just like my feelings for you.”

“Blegh! Bleeeggh!”

This was addictive.

With Song Song’s renewed retching as my background music, I continued.

“What Song-i just said is correct. But the premise is different here. This isn’t a snow-covered hill. It’s a hill where the snow has already melted. No matter how hard you roll the snowball down it, it won’t get much bigger.”

“The snowball you’re talking about is mana, then.”

“Team Leader Choi, you catch on fast. Yes, a Mana Cultivation Method works the same way. If all you start with is a speck of dust, it’ll still be a speck of dust no matter how much you roll it.”

“The lower the rank, the lower the ceiling. Is that what you mean?”

“Exactly.”

There was a saying that once you were an F-rank, you were an F-rank forever.

That was how difficult it was to break free of the rank you had been assigned.

But on extremely rare occasions, some people managed to pluck that star from the sky.

Second Awakeners. That was what they were called—and it was also the mask I was currently wearing.

“After my second awakening made me a C-rank Hunter, the effects increased dramatically. That was when a little snow finally began to accumulate on what had been a grassy hill.”

“Come to think of it, your results at the time were…”

“My mana reserves were C-rank, but even then, my control was A-rank. You know why, right?”

“The Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.”

Team Leader Choi groaned.

“So it wasn’t a mistake on the Association’s part.”

As I became famous and my past actions came to light, that part was concluded to have been a measurement error.

As a result, the Bucheon Association, which had conducted the retest, had taken a mountain of abuse. From their perspective, it must have felt deeply unfair.

“The Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique, which you and Butler Kim call a Mana Cultivation Method, has two effects. The first is an increase in mana. And the second is…”

Butler Kim picked up the thread.

“Mana control on an entirely different level.”

“Correct.”

Qi—called mana here and internal energy in Murim—could differ as greatly as heaven and earth depending on how it was used.

The Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique was a Peak martial art. It accumulated qi slowly, but its stability rivaled that of a Supreme Peak martial art.

“Learning it alone should lead to dramatic progress. We’ll keep an eye on the new recruits for now… For the time being, only those of you here should focus on learning the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique. And of course, this must be done in absolute secrecy.”

“…”

“…”

What was with their reactions?

A heavy silence descended over the hospital room. All four of them stared blankly at me, mouths hanging open.

“Did you just say… you were going to teach us a Mana Cultivation Method?”

“Not a Mana Cultivation Method. The Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.”

“Yes, yes. The Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.”

Team Leader Choi’s eyelids trembled.

“You’re going to teach it to us?”

“That’s why I brought it, obviously. Did you think I brought it here just to show off?”

I looked around at everyone and continued.

“As you all know, we won’t last long at our current level. Lee Jungryong won’t come after us right away because of the recent incident, but it’s only a matter of time. But… what if we had the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique?”

Im Kkeokjeong, who had been sitting with his mouth wide open, shouted.

“Jin! Family’s! Cultivation! Technique!”

“Ah, now that’s a good reaction. Anyway, I made this decision after careful consideration, so for the time being, I’d like you to follow my instructions without complaint. Understood?”

The four people here would be the first in line. Next would come the newly hired Hunters.

I would put them through a rigorous screening process, then turn them into both Hunters and martial artists.

Elites capable of handling two or three Hunters of the same rank with ease.

“Well, then…”

I looked over the still-dazed group one by one, then crooked a finger at one of them.

“Let’s start with Team Leader Choi.”

At that moment, a holographic window appeared over his still-stunned face.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A Quest, Back, Back—Let’s See Your Back!, has been generated!

“…”

That was a title that made me not want to do it for some reason.

SYSTEM

Quest
Back, Back—Let’s See Your Back!
Unlike the Murim, your modern life had been peaceful.
But reality is a cesspool!
Alarmed by this harsh reality, you have decided to pass martial arts on to trustworthy friends.
Whether this choice proves poisonous or beneficial… depends on your decisions and abilities.
May fortune in the martial arts be with you!
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Guide the acquisition of **Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique** ***(Incomplete)***
Reward: A considerable amount of EXP
Repeat Quest
???
Failure: In the worst-case scenario, suffer **qi deviation**

"…"

Who the hell came up with this quest title?

I really did need to see his back. I had to send internal energy into the Mingmen acupoint in his lower back and teach him how to circulate it. But after reading that title, I suddenly really, really didn't want to.

"Whew. Team Leader Choi."

"Yes."

"Your back."

"What?"

"Ah, never mind. Take the position I'm about to show you. Butler Kim and everyone else, guard the hospital room and make sure no outsiders enter. Above all, no one is to touch either of us. Understood?"

"Of course."

Butler Kim nodded firmly and cast a spell. Each time he swept his staff through the air while chanting, an invisible barrier spread around the hospital room.

Meanwhile, Team Leader Choi removed his shirt, awkwardly sat cross-legged, and presented his back to me.

"What are you planning to do to me now?"

"…You really know how to phrase things strangely."

I ought to give him qi deviation. Damn it.

I placed my hand on Team Leader Choi's Mingmen acupoint.

From this point on, I had to be extremely careful. Even the most formidable Murim master was practically defenseless while circulating their qi.

"Close your eyes and focus on the mana inside your body. Whatever happens, endure it. Is anything bothering you right now? If so, tell me now."

"My right shoulder blade is a little…"

"Does it hurt?"

"It's itchy."

"…This is driving me crazy. Here?"

Scratch, scratch.

When I reached out and scratched it for him, Team Leader Choi's voice relaxed considerably.

"Yes, right there. That feels wonderful."

"They used to call me the Filial Son's Hand."[1541]

"And the area around my underwear is a little tight, so…"

"Are you crazy? Handle that part yourself. Did I put you in handcuffs?"

"Ah, so that was an option. I'm very tense right now."

[1541] The Korean term *hyojason* means a back-scratcher and literally translates as "filial son's hand."

"Whew. It's all right. Sorry I got worked up for no reason."

"It isn't your fault, Taekyung. If I'd known this would happen, I would have worn a thong."

Does this guy actually know his way around underwear…?

Team Leader Choi was so nervous that he was blurting out whatever came to mind. I warned him in a low, level voice.

"From now on, if you open your mouth, you're dead. Focus on one thing and one thing only: where the mana is flowing and how."

"Understood."

"Even if your shoulder blade itches, endure it. Even if something gets caught in your underwear, endure it. Do you understand?"

"May I ask what exactly we're about to do?"

"I'm going to move your mana through True Qi Guidance. After that, I'll perform a Small Circulation according to the formula of the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, then finish by circulating your qi and regulating your breathing."

"…"

"Did you understand any of that? Be honest."

"Be honest?"

"Yes."

After a brief silence, Team Leader Choi answered.

"You lost me at True Qi Guidance."

"Then close your eyes and shut your mouth. If you start wiggling your ass while saying things like, 'Something's caught in my underwear,' I'll kill you before I die."

"I'll keep that in mind."

His answer rang with resolve. I felt Team Leader Choi's body, which had been rigid with tension, gradually relax.

He was a novice taking his first step into the unfamiliar world of martial arts.

It didn't matter how much social experience Team Leader Choi had accumulated, how many languages he spoke, or what kind of knowledge he possessed.

"Then we'll begin."

Everything depended on me now.

After steadying my breathing, I drew internal energy up from my dantian, channeled it through my palm, and sent it into Team Leader Choi's Mingmen acupoint.

Slowly. Carefully.

Ssshh.

The moment the Scorching Yang Qi, imbued with Extreme Yang energy, entered his body, the System fired a signal flare as if it had been waiting.

Ding.

SYSTEM

True Qi Guidance begins.

I had removed the waste accumulated inside Mom and Hayeon's bodies once before.

But in terms of difficulty, this was as different as heaven and earth.

True Qi Guidance meant leading the energy inside another person's body in whatever direction I wanted.

The energy Team Leader Choi possessed was incomparably more abundant than an ordinary person's.

And cleaner than I expected.

No, let me correct that. It wasn't merely cleaner than expected. At this level, it was exceptionally clean.

His muscles and bones were sturdy, his sinews and meridians strong, and his acupoints as clear as a highway at dawn. There was hardly any waste inside him.

What the hell? He said he hadn't learned a Mana Cultivation Method.

Team Leader Choi's Hunter license was B-rank. The energy I usually sensed from him was exactly at that level.

The only things that set him apart from an ordinary B-rank Hunter were the combat instincts born of his sharp mind and the power of his high-end equipment.

Honestly, for Cheon Taemin's only blood descendant, he'd always seemed a little disappointing.

Outstanding leadership. A brilliant mind and decisive judgment.

Despite all that, he was inevitably underestimated.

Anyone would pale beside Cheon Taemin, the hero who had saved all of humanity.

But now I had changed my mind a little.

At this level... a little help would be enough for him to reach a higher realm in no time.

An A-rank Hunter? No. I intended to turn Team Leader Choi into a Peak master. His basic hardware was far too good to leave to rot.

If the others were even half as capable as Team Leader Choi, this would be much easier.

With that carefree thought, I sent the Scorching Yang Qi flowing through him. Before long, more than one jiazi's[1542] worth of my internal energy was winding its way through his body.

[1542] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here to measure accumulated internal energy.

Whoosh!

I felt the body beneath my palm twitch. By now, he was probably experiencing heat unlike anything he had ever felt before.

Paying it no mind, I gathered the energy scattered throughout his body and drove it through dozens of acupoints.

Team Leader Choi had to remember this. From now on, he would have to travel this path on his own thousands, tens of thousands of times.

Once the body remembers, the rest is easy.

The pace was astonishingly fast.

Before long, the energy I was guiding had reached half a jiazi,[1543] and what little waste remained was cleanly burned away by the heat of the Scorching Yang Qi.

Now for the last step.

I had gathered the scattered energy. It was time to store it in the dantian. Once that was done, a complete circulation would be achieved, and he could be said to have taken his first step as a martial artist.

But then…

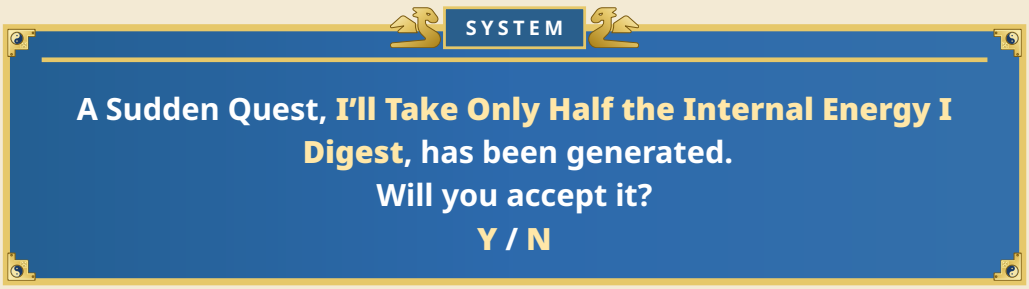
What the hell is that?

When I reached Team Leader Choi's dantian, I stopped dead.

A massive mass of qi occupied half of his dantian.

Then came the System notification.

Ding.



[1543] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here to measure accumulated internal energy.

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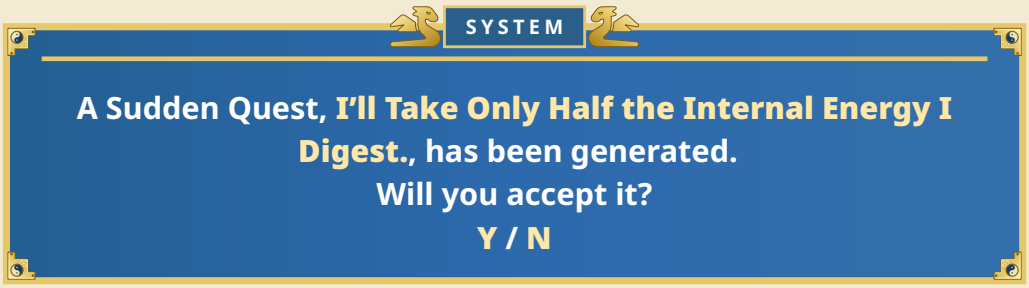
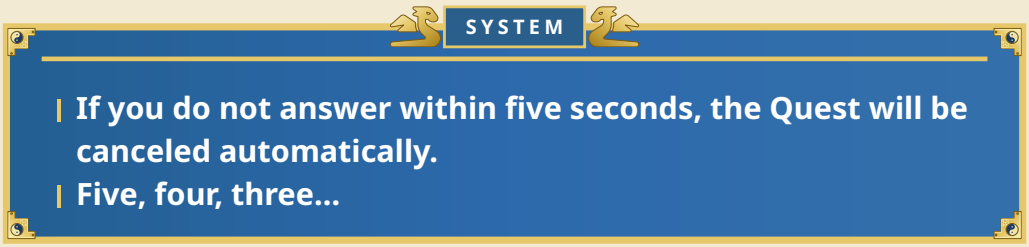
Ding.



Damn it. Why now?

I was dying to check the Quest window.

But I was in the middle of True Qi Guidance. Circulating my own qi would be one thing, but if I let go of control here, I could easily suffer an Internal Injury.



Do I go for it or not?

Judging by the Quest title, it wanted me to do something about that thing in Team Leader Choi's dantian. Even at a glance, it contained well over one jiazi's[1544] worth of energy.

Fuck it. I don't know. It's not like I'm going to die.

Accept!

Ding.

That had been close. The moment the notification confirmed that the Quest had been accepted, I realized what I had to do.

[1544] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Here, it measures an equivalent amount of accumulated internal energy.

SYSTEM

The mysterious qi has been dormant for a long time, and its owner lacks the power to control it. Now is the time for you to step forward!

Just as I thought.

I had encountered a situation like this once before in Murim.

I dredged up an old memory.

Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng.

From the moment I first opened my eyes in Murim, the internal energy of the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng had lain dormant inside my dantian.

It was internal energy that the Third Rate wastrel Jin Taekyung—not me—had been unable to fully digest.

That was when I first learned that even if you consumed an elixir, you couldn't make its power your own unless you had the ability to digest it.

Just like Team Leader Choi now.

He was an outstanding talent compared to that Third Rate wastrel, but without a Mana Cultivation Method, he had no way to control such an enormous reserve of energy—nearly one jiazi's worth.

The Quest wanted me to serve as his digestive aid.

But how does Team Leader Choi have that much energy in the first place?

Now that I thought about it, it pissed me off.

I'd been put through the fucking wringer in Murim and had only just managed to accumulate a little more than one jiazi. What the hell had this guy ever done to have such monstrous energy deposited in his dantian?

Ah, right. His maternal grandfather was Cheon Taemin.

Was this what they meant by being born with a hero's silver spoon?

I gave up on thinking about it. Right now, I needed to focus on breaking down that mysterious energy of unknown origin.

And this time, I was confident.

Let's do this.

A bolt of Scorching Yang Qi shot forward like a spear and plunged into the solid mass of qi. A combined total of more than two jiazi's worth of qi collided and tore into each other.

Rumble.

As the clash erupted inside his dantian, Team Leader Choi's body began to shake violently.

The hospital room had become an impregnable fortress, sealed against all visitors.

Butler Kim, Im Kkeokjeong, and Song Song watched the two young men with fascination.

“Hngh.”

“Hup.”

“Ugh.”

“Kk.”

Every time the veins bulged on Jin Taekyung’s forearm, Team Leader Choi’s body trembled.

Before long, his back arched, and a groan escaped through his clenched teeth.

“Haaagh!”

Song Song muttered as she watched.

“His back arched like a bow…”

Im Kkeokjeong, lying on the bed, asked, “What did you just say, Miss Song?”

“Nothing. I was just saying it was gross and fascinating.”

“Ah, you mean that black sweat?”

“…Yes.”

Song Song had a lot she wanted to say, but she held it in and nodded.

After all, the black sweat pouring from Team Leader Choi’s entire body was every bit as gross and fascinating.

“My God, what even is that…?”

As a Hunter, you saw all kinds of bizarre things. But this was the first time she had ever seen someone sweat black.

The pitch-black, sticky fluid wasn’t particularly abundant, but it gave off an unbelievable stench.

“Ugh, it reeks.”

“Damn, that smell is awful.”

As the two of them pinched their noses, Butler Kim spoke.

“That is waste accumulated inside his body being expelled through his sweat. It is one of the benefits of a Mana Cultivation Method.”

“Waste?”

“Kim hyung,[1545] is that really so impressive?”

“Of course. Even healing magic cannot remove waste from inside the body.”

Song Song thought for a moment, then replied, “It can. A truly top-tier healer could do it. But if what you’re saying is true… that’s incredible. Even healing potions retain trace amounts of Troll toxicity. You’re saying it can flush out that as well.”

“That is one of the remarkable aspects of a Mana Cultivation Method.”

[1545] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is familiar.

“Who created this Mana Cultivation Method, exactly? And how?”

Song Song was an experienced Hunter, but she had never heard the term *Mana Cultivation Method* in her life. It was just as unfamiliar to Im Kkeokjeong, despite his twenty-year career.

“Exactly. I’ve been a Hunter all these years, and this is the first I’ve heard of anything like this. Martial arts, sorcery, whatever it is.”

“During the Great Cataclysm, the Elder created the first Mana Cultivation Method. It is treated as a closely guarded secret, so it is only natural that neither of you would know of it.”

“When you say the Elder…”

“You are thinking of the right person.”

Cheon Taemin. The hero who had saved all of humanity and the greatest Hunter in the world.

Butler Kim continued slowly.

“A Mana Cultivation Method is a powerful weapon in its own right. Many incidents occurred because of it, and most have vanished from history. It truly was an age of cataclysmic upheaval.”

What had happened? Why had Cheon Taemin’s Mana Cultivation Method fallen into the hands of an ambitious man like Lee Jungryong instead of his sole blood descendant?

Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong had many more questions, but they fell silent.

It wasn’t merely because Butler Kim’s expression had become unbearably bitter. The moment he finished speaking, an ominous change came over the two men.

“Nggh!”

“Hup!”

Jin Taekyung and Team Leader Choi groaned at the same time.

Thick veins bulged across their exposed skin, and deep furrows formed between their brows.

Team Leader Choi’s reaction grew increasingly violent. His entire body trembled as though caught in an earthquake.

“Team Leader Choi!”

“Is something seriously wrong?”

Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong instinctively stepped forward, but Butler Kim held out an arm to stop them.

“No. There can be no physical contact while practicing a Mana Cultivation Method.”

“But…”

“Hunter Jin Taekyung is not someone who would put the Young Master in danger.”

Butler Kim looked at the two of them, concern and trust mingling in his eyes.

The trembling intensified, along with the groans of pain.

Before long, his faith was vindicated.

“Haaah…”

At some point, Team Leader Choi’s lips parted, releasing a calm breath.

It signaled the completion of his first complete circulation. It also meant that he had become a martial artist who had learned the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.

“Young Master?”

At Butler Kim’s call, Team Leader Choi’s eyes slowly opened. Astonishment and joy filled them.

“This is…”

Team Leader Choi—Choi Minwoo—clenched his fists tightly.

The massive energy surging from his dantian raced freely through his body.

Normally, his mana would have remained scattered throughout him. Now he could move it at will.

Not only that, but the amount of mana he possessed had nearly doubled.

So this is a Mana Cultivation Method.

As Choi Minwoo calmly examined his condition, he reconsidered.

No. It isn’t the power of a Mana Cultivation Method. It’s the power of the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique.

And it had only been possible because of one person’s ability.

“Mr. Jin.”

Choi Minwoo slowly turned around. Jin Taekyung still had his eyes closed and was breathing deeply.

The air around him trembled. An active volcano stood there, ready to erupt at any moment.

He’s strong. Unbelievably strong.

Was he always this powerful?

Now that he could properly control his mana, Choi Minwoo could glimpse a fraction of the power Jin Taekyung possessed.

Every breath Jin Taekyung exhaled released waves of fiery qi that heated the hospital room.

It was November. The first snow had fallen only a week ago, yet everyone felt parched, and heat haze shimmered above the floor.

Just then, Choi Minwoo’s eyes slowly widened.

What… is that?

An illusion created by the heat haze? Or something real?

He couldn’t tell. Before he knew it, everyone in the hospital room was staring openmouthed at the sight before them.

Whoosh.

Jin Taekyung's cross-legged body was rising into the air.

Little by little. Slowly, without stopping.

Above his head, blazing blue flames formed the shape of flower petals.

One flower. Then two.

And just as the third and final flower was about to take shape, Jin Taekyung's eyes flew open.

Whoosh! Thud!

Like a bird struck by an arrow, Jin Taekyung plummeted and slammed his butt onto the floor. A piercing scream tore from his throat.

"Fuck! My tailbone!"

The air in the hospital room froze solid.

I screamed at the top of my lungs.

"Aaaargh!"

It hurt. My tailbone hurt from slamming into the floor, but my heart hurt ten times more from losing the perfect opportunity.

"It was almost done! I almost had it!"

Damn it. With only one step left to go, the Supreme Peak realm had slipped out of reach.

I didn't know whether my understanding of martial arts was too shallow or there was some other reason.

Maybe it was both. But what mattered was that I had no idea when another opportunity like this would come.

"Damn iiiit!"

I could have achieved Three Flowers Gather at the Crown in one stroke and become a Supreme Peak master!

As I pounded the floor and wailed, System notifications pierced my ears.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

Trance has been dispelled!
Internal Energy has risen to 100 years!
You have achieved a great feat! You have acquired the Title I'm a Master!
The Sudden Quest, I'll Take Only Half the Internal Energy I Digest., has been successfully completed!
The Repeat Quest, Back, Back—Let's See Your Back!, has been successfully completed!
The realm of Fire Gate Divine Technique has risen to Seven Stars!
You have acquired a massive amount of EXP!
Level Up!

...
...
...

"Just leave me alone!"

Everything had been perfect. While melting the energy that had been solidified in Team Leader Choi's dantian, I had absorbed half of it. My mind had gone blank, and I had momentarily slipped into a trance.

But...

"Why! Why can't I be happy!"

Gaining half a jiazi's worth of internal energy? Great!

Acquiring a Title, completing Quests, raising the realm of the Fire Gate Divine Technique by one stage, and even leveling up—all of it was great. It was all good, so why!

"Why didn't I reach the Supreme Peak realm!"

As I howled toward the ceiling, whispers reached my ears.

"Has something happened to Mr. Jin?"

"I'm not certain, but I have heard that some people end up crippled while practicing a Mana Cultivation Method..."

"More importantly, did everyone see those flower petals just now? Was I the only one? Why isn't anyone saying anything?"

"Song-i, you saw them too? I thought I'd been dropped into the Goyang flower expo."

The concern and astonishment in their voices snapped me back to my senses.

That was right. It wasn't over yet. If those three had even half as much energy as Team Leader Choi, I might still have a chance to advance to the Supreme Peak realm.

I still have three test subjects.

With the resolve of Admiral Yi Sun-sin before the Battle of Myeongnyang,[1546] I spoke.

“Everyone, pay attention.”

“…?”

“…?”

“Take off your tops immediately. That’s an order.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

The Repeat Quest, Back, Back—Let’s See Your Back!, has been generated!

“Back, back—let’s see your back!”

The others edged away, their faces pale with fear.

[1546] The Battle of Myeongnyang was Admiral Yi Sun-sin’s famous 1597 naval victory, achieved against overwhelming odds.

Chapter 293

Sss. Hooo.

Only the soft sound of breathing drifted through the hospital room. Standing guard at the door, I watched the others focus on circulating their qi and regulating their breathing.

Their cross-legged postures had been awkward at first, but they were gradually getting the hang of it.

Not bad.

Team Leader Choi, Butler Kim, Song Song, and finally Im Kkeokjeong.

Before sunset, all four had succeeded in completing a complete circulation. Before long, they were able to perform the Small Circulation on their own.

Not bad for a first step. No, this is better than I expected.

None of the others possessed energy as vast as Team Leader Choi's, but Butler Kim and Song Song were mages. They were already adept at handling mana and adapted quickly.

The biggest surprise, however, was someone else.

Im Kkeokjeong.

I thought he'd struggle for a while…

I'd forgotten. Im Kkeokjeong was the only Second Awakener among everyone I knew. Had it come from grueling effort? Or a stroke of heavenly luck?

Whatever the reason, Im Kkeokjeong had already once broken past the limits given to him.

Maybe there was a reason he underwent a Second Awakening.

Judging by what he had shown me, Im Kkeokjeong might have the greatest potential for growth.

He was still a D-rank Hunter. He had plenty of steps left to climb.

I won't have to worry about the aftereffects of his injuries, either.

Repeatedly circulating his qi would naturally improve his Muscles and Bones and Sinews and Meridians.

If Im Kkeokjeong could overcome the psychological issues, such as his trauma, he would be able to return to the Guild before long.

And then…

The Guild will have changed quite a bit by then, too.

The changes had already begun. Lee Jungryong had drawn the knife hidden up his sleeve and turned it against us. Now he owed us compensation for it.

With that compensation as its foundation, the Peace Guild would achieve astonishing growth. These people needed to stand at the forefront.

Someone had to run the Guild. Someone else had to identify talented, trustworthy people and turn them into loyal members of the Peace Guild.

And those people would be given martial arts.

We need blades of our own.

The moment that thought crossed my mind, Team Leader Choi finished his Small Circulation and opened his eyes with an exhale. A sharp gleam flashed through them.

Starting with him, the others opened their eyes one after another.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Thanks to your excellent instruction, several people have reached One Star in the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.

The Title Trainee has changed to Training Instructor!

A martial arts drill instructor, huh.

Was this heaven telling me to work them to death for a while?

I grinned at the people still savoring the afterglow of circulating their qi.

A week passed in the blink of an eye.

During that time, Lee Jungryong and the Peace Guild secretly concluded their negotiations, two more mutated Gate incidents occurred, and a post on a Hunter community site drew a great deal of attention.

How I Got Hired by the Peace Guild

I'm a C-rank Hunter who used to work on the Security Team of a certain Guild.

I was originally with a major Guild, but my senior coworker was such a pain in the ass (he's a traitor to the country) that the stress got too bad. I quit a few days ago and was browsing job sites when I saw that the Peace Guild had opened its general recruitment. So I applied on a whim, you know?

Then I didn't hear anything back, so I figured I'd been rejected.

I already knew their selection process was brutal, so I wasn't expecting anything in the first place.

But they contacted me after two weeks and told me to report to work tomorrow!

Anyone else starting with me tomorrow, raise your hand!

> ㄴ **(Best comment):** You only submitted an application to the Peace Guild and got hired? Hahahahahaha. Some unemployed bastard's sitting there writing a web novel.
>
> ㄴ **???:** Hyung.[1547] This bastard's laughing.
>
> ㄴ **???:** Leave him alone. At least let him dream about joining the Peace Guild.
>
> ㄴ That ending.
>
> ㄴ The OP is seriously an idiot. If you're going to write fiction, at least make it believable. The Peace Guild rejected people from the top teams of major Guilds, but some C-rank Security Team guy sends in an application and gets hired? Hahaha. Thanks for the laugh.
>
> ㄴ Is it really that brutal?
>
> ㄴ I applied this time, and the competition was 47:1. They even made us take personality and aptitude tests before the interview.
>
> ㄴ What the hell? Personality and aptitude tests? Is this high school?
>
> ㄴ Proof that the Peace Guild thinks Hunters are weaklings.
>
> ㄴ On the other hand, their basic allowance and incentives are incomparably higher than anywhere else.
>
> ㄴ Please think of me as a weakling.
>
> ㄴ Come to think of it, the Peace Guild must be loaded. People are even transferring over from major Guilds.
>
> ㄴ Exactly. I heard they have exclusive rights to more than twenty Gates alone.
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** I'm the person who wrote this. I just called HR, and they said I was hired because Jin Taekyung told them to hire me.
>
> ㄴ Hahahaha. How would Lord Fuck even know an unemployed loser like you? Stop writing fiction and go to sleep.
>
> ㄴ Thanks for the web novel. I enjoyed it.
>
> ㄴ By the way, are there any decent web novels these days?
>
> ㄴ I recommend *Login Murim*. It's pretty good once you get through the early modern-world chapters.
>
> ㄴ Welcome, Zerobic.
>
> ㄴ That bastard author has been serializing it for ten years and hasn't released extra chapters even once.

Under normal circumstances, the post would have been dismissed as the ramblings of an attention seeker.

[1547] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

However, the post proudly took first place in the weekly rankings, accompanied by countless recommendations and comments from people making a pilgrimage to the site.

All because of another post uploaded the following evening.

Guys, that web-novel villain from yesterday was for real;

I'm one of the people who got accepted by the Peace Guild this time. Today, I was touring the Guild house with the other new hires when I saw Lord Fuck, you know?

I was just watching him from a distance, terrified by the majesty of him dragging around slippers with the soles torn off, when he suddenly made a U-turn, grabbed one of us, and asked if he was from the ** Guild Security Team.

The dopey-looking guy said yes, and Lord Fuck started laughing like a maniac, yelled, "Irasshaimase!"[1548] and all that shit, then left.

I knew Lord Fuck had a weird personality, but he seems to be an even bigger lunatic than I imagined.

(Photo attached.)

I'm posting all the proof before I go so nobody says I'm lying.

> ㄴ **(Best comment):** I'm the person who got the best comment last time. In apology, I'm going to perform a full-body prostration and leave.
>
> ㄴ Looking at the proof photo, I think this might actually be real…?
>
> ㄴ Wait, what? How does a C-rank Hunter from a Security Team end up at the Peace Guild?
>
> ㄴ It actually happened…
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** The web-novel villain was assigned to the Security Team instead of a raid team.
>
> ㄴ Oh, then I can see why they'd take him. At that level, it's not even nepotism. He basically just changed jobs.
>
> ㄴ They say Korea runs on blood ties, regional ties, and school ties. I guess he's only human, but I'm still a little disappointed in Lord Fuck.
>
> ㄴ Who the hell are you to be disappointed?
>
> ㄴ Here's why the bastards bashing Lord Fuck are idiots: Lord Fuck walks around in slippers with the soles peeling off because he donated almost his entire fortune to establish a foundation for Gate victims.
>
> ㄴ The comment above is stating facts. Anyone insulting Lord Fuck needs to be beaten half to death with a slipper before they'll come to their senses.
>
> ㄴ Keep showing people goodwill, and they'll start thinking you're Dooly.[1549]

[1548] *Irasshaimase* is a Japanese greeting used to welcome customers into a shop or restaurant.

> ㄴ But where did the OP go? Tell us more.
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** I'm on my way to a company dinner.
>
> ㄴ A welcome party for the new hires?
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** Yeah. I've already been in the car for an hour. We must be going pretty far.
>
> ㄴ Oh. Is Lord Fuck coming too?
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** Yeah. But I don't see the Guild Master or any of the other Team Leaders.
>
> ㄴ The Peace Guild must be great at team building. Maybe it's because they're still a new Guild?
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** I'm not sure about that, but… the atmosphere feels kind of bad. I asked a Senior who joined earlier than me, and he told me to sleep as much as I could on the way there.
>
> ㄴ Why?
>
> ㄴ Maybe the company dinner is going to last a long time. Who likes drinking with people they aren't even close to?
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** Maybe? Oh, I think we're here.
>
> ㄴ Don't drink too much. And don't forget to come back with the rest of the story.
>
> ㄴ Have fun!
>
> ㄴ **(OP):** It looks like a good restaurant. I'm looking forward to seeing what we're having for dinner, haha. I'll be back soon.

That was the OP's final comment.

"We'll be having dinner inside a Gate."

Murmurs rose from all around at my declaration.

"Excuse me?"

"Huh?"

"Sorry, but did I hear you correctly?"

"I think you said we're having dinner at a Gate. I must have misheard."

"Ah, right."

I didn't even need to look at their faces. The ones having that innocent conversation were the new hires on their first day.

[1549] Dooly is a Korean cartoon dinosaur whose catchphrase is "Hoi!" The line plays on the similar sound of *hoi* ("goodwill") and means that repeated goodwill can be taken for granted.

The people who had joined only two or three weeks earlier, however, reacted differently.

“I knew this would happen.”

“Ah, fuck…”

“Good thing I brought potions.”

“Hyung,[1550] do you have any arrows to spare?”

“Yeah. I brought an extra two hundred for emergencies, just in case.”

“Then could I get a hundred?”

They hadn’t joined even a month apart, but their reactions were worlds apart.

The veterans swore under their breath like they were sighing, then swiftly pulled armor and equipment from their backpacks.

Clack! Clack! Clack!

Was this how a teacher felt?

A satisfied smile spread across my face at the results of repeated training.

I turned toward the greenhorns who still had no idea what was happening and asked,

“You all brought everything with you, right?”

The new hires nodded.

“Uh, yes. You told us to bring it all, so…”

“Put your bags down, take out your equipment, and put it on.”

“Excuse me? Is this some kind of mock battle?”

“Mock battle, my ass. You don’t improve much doing that. Real combat is best.”

“…?”

Suspicion crept into their innocent eyes.

“Then, perhaps…”

“Are we really going into a Gate?”

“Yes. A raid to celebrate joining the Peace Guild! What do you think? Sounds great, right?”

“…”

“The new people don’t seem too excited. What does everyone else think?”

The people I’d worked to the bone for the past few weeks gritted their teeth and shouted.

“That’s a wonderful idea!”

“As expected of King Taekyung.”

“Wow. This. Is. Great!”

Hmm. Just as I thought.

[1550] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

This was also the effect of learning. They clearly remembered what had happened to the few brave souls who had openly contradicted my opinions.

The logic of *we can't be the only ones who suffer* had probably played a part as well.

Exactly. Everyone should suffer together.

If the new hires were Pomeranians, the others were already Tosa mastiffs.[1551]

With the atmosphere blazing with the determination to die together, the new hires hesitated before shouting,

"B-But nobody told us about this! The notice said we'd only be doing a simple workshop for the first week after joining the Guild…"

"Yes. This is the workshop."

"What Guild holds a workshop inside a Gate? For an entire week!"

"The Peace Guild."

"That's ridiculous!"

"Does everyone else think so, too?"

I turned my head slightly. The Senior Tosa mastiffs[1552] who had tasted hell for several weeks bared their teeth and shouted.

"Why wouldn't it make sense? It does! Absolutely!"

"Obviously this is a workshop!"

"Who rents a vacation house for a workshop these days? You're supposed to bond by killing monsters together inside a Gate!"

"We can't be the only ones getting fucked!"

That last shout was so blatant it bordered on desperate. Hearing it forced me to reflect deeply.

I guess I need to work them even harder.

They couldn't be allowed to think of this as suffering. I planned to condition—or rather, train—them until they accepted all of it as perfectly natural.

"All right, everyone quiet!"

Ding.

SYSTEM

The effect of the Title Training Instructor activates!
The trainees who heard your shout become tense!

"Form ranks!"

"Form raaanks!"

"Too quiet! Form ranks!"

[1551] The Tosa mastiff is a Japanese dog breed developed for fighting.
[1552] The Tosa mastiff is a Japanese dog breed developed for fighting.

“Form raaanks!”
Even after repeating the command back in unison, they all looked dazed.
I smiled at their bitter expressions.
“Now, follow me inside in order. Left foot. Left foot.”
Clack! Clack! Clack!
The human train set off toward the Gate.

Chapter 294

A week ago, after several days of relentless negotiations with Lee Jungryong's side, Team Leader Choi got everything he wanted.

Exclusive rights to more than twenty Gates, real estate, and an enormous amount of cash. I didn't know the exact figure, but the total value was clearly astronomical.

They were valuable spoils we could never have obtained if the ten Black Hunters and the close aides dispatched by Myeongdong Guild Master Park Tae Seop hadn't fallen into our hands.

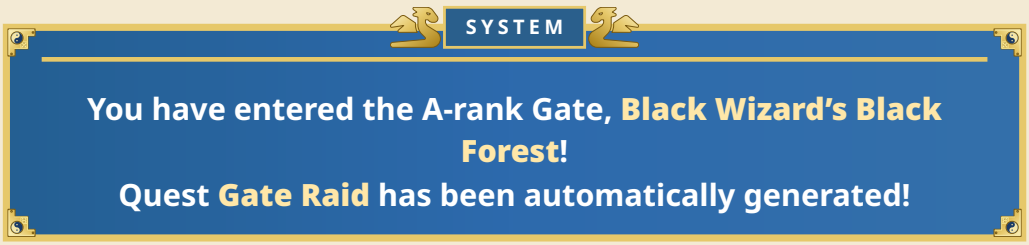
The same went for this place.

Calling out the cadence, I led the way through the mana field.

Ssshhhk.

That sticky, unpleasant, yet familiar sensation unique to mana washed over me, and everything around me changed.

Ding.



"Left foot, left foot! One, two, three, four! Halt!"

"One, two! Fall in!"

By the time the human train came to a stop amid crisp call-and-response, more than fifty people had entered the Gate.

Darkness blanketed the forest, and faint moonlight filtered through the gaunt branches.

The new hires, who had realized what was happening too late, looked around in panic.

"Gasp!"

"W-We're screwed."

"Wait. What rank is this Gate? Why is it so huge?"

The third-week Tosa mastiffs, on the other hand, were completely unfazed.

"Black Wizard's Black Forest again?"

"Ugh, I'm going to puke."

"Good thing I brought my war hammer."

They had joined less than a month apart, but the difference between them was enormous.

The day-one pups listening to the Tosa mastiffs turned deathly pale.

“B-Black Wizard’s Black Forest?”

“It’s an A-rank Gate!”

An A-rank Gate: Black Wizard’s Black Forest.

Even people who knew nothing about the place could get a rough idea from the name alone. The eerie atmosphere, the forest so unsettling that the mere sight of it sent chills down your spine.

This was a realm ruled by a black wizard—a necromancer.

“Lord Fuck! Senior Jin Taekyung!”

One of the pups rushed over and pleaded with me.

“Please, can’t you let me out?”

“Why?”

“I’m really scared of ghosts. Regular monsters are fine, but ghouls and skeletons… I don’t think I can handle them.”

“Trauma?”

“Nothing that serious. I’m just scared.”

“Perfect. This is a great chance to experience them in 4D.[1553] They’re monsters, anyway.”

“No, that’s not…”

“And I’m pretty sure you wrote on your Guild application that you didn’t have any problems like that.”

“I only wrote that so I’d get accepted in the first place… Please. I can’t even watch horror movies with my girlfriend.”

“Oh, you have a girlfriend. I see. Over here!”

I crooked a finger.

From among the grinning Tosa mastiffs, one man shot forward like a bullet.

“You called?”

“Yeah.”

It was Kim Jinsoo, who had quietly taken on the role of leader among the Tosa mastiffs.

He had good leadership skills and excellent combat ability, so whenever we went on a raid together, he served as my right hand.

Of course, I’d long since stopped speaking formally to him.

“I have a special assignment for you. It concerns this gentleman here.”

“Yes.”

“Put him in front.”

The pup had just begun to sigh in relief when he sucked in a sharp breath.

[1553] 4D cinema adds physical effects, such as moving seats, wind, or water, to a film.

“D-Did you say in front?”

“Why? Is there a problem? Judging by that tower shield, you’re clearly a tank.”

“But…”

“If you want to sit this out, go ahead. Just be prepared to get fired.”

“F-Fired?”

“If you refuse to join a raid because you’re afraid of ghosts, why would I keep employing you? Besides, are there any ghosts inside a Gate? They’re all monsters. Jinsoo, am I wrong?”

Kim Jinsoo answered without hesitation.

“You are absolutely right—a hundred, a thousand times over.”

“If everything here were a ghost, why would I bring Hunters? I’d bring exorcists instead. Right?”

“Absolutely right—a thousand, ten thousand times over.”

“That’s our Jinsoo. You certainly have a way with words.”

“Thank you.”

“So, would you like to remain a Hunter with the Peace Guild, or would you rather get fired and change careers to become an exorcist?”

The pup replied, his face rigid.

“I-I’ll be a Hunter.”

“Then if you run away during combat, I’ll send you to heaven with my own hands. Okay?”

“O-Okay.”

“Okay. Front! Okay! Heaven!”

I waved my hand, and Kim Jinsoo grabbed the man by the arm and dragged him away.

We’d put them through a fairly rigorous selection process, but there was always one guy like that wherever you went.

What? He’s so scared of ghosts that he can’t even watch a horror movie with his girlfriend?

Damn it. What a load of bullshit.

I wasn’t angry about the girlfriend part. Really.

“…”

Whooosh.

The eerie wind circling through the forest made the empty space at my side feel cold. I shuddered once, then stepped toward the trees.

The conversation behind me gradually faded into the distance.

“E-Excuse me, mister.”

The frightened voice of one of the pups mixed with the Tosa mastiff’s blunt reply.

“What?”

“Where is Hunter Jin Taekyung going?”

“He’s going to round up the prey.”

“What?”

“That guy’s nickname is the Pied Piper.”

The Tosa mastiff added cheerfully,

“I can’t be the only one going through hell. Let’s do our best together.”

“…”

I roamed the forest, making enough noise to ensure everything nearby could hear me, and it didn’t take long to get a response.

Crack! Rumble!

—Guaaaar!

—Ngh… nghhh…

Click, clack, clatter-clatter-clatter!

Grotesque cries rang out as the corpses sleeping beneath the earth and inside their graves awakened.

Ghouls with rotting flesh dripping from their bodies. Skeletons with not a scrap of flesh left on their gaunt white bones.

In an instant, the cursed dead known as Undead Monsters covered the forest and hills.

“Hey, hey! I’m going slowly, so make sure you keep up! Got it?”

—Guaaaaaar!

Rat-tat-tat-tat!

The old image of zombies shambling around with limp bodies was hopelessly outdated.

More than once, seeing these bastards sprint had made me wonder if they had trained at Taereung Athletes’ Village.[1554]

Of course, they still weren’t fast enough to catch me.

We’ve got new hires today, so I should bring back a smaller group.

I raced through the forest, glancing over my shoulder every so often to check their numbers.

There were roughly a hundred and fifty of them.

That was three times the number of people on our side, but even this was fewer than usual.

[1554] Taereung Athletes’ Village was a training complex for South Korean national-team athletes.

For one thing, ghouls and skeletons weren't particularly powerful monsters. For another, our side had prepared thoroughly and developed plenty of nerve.

There's a reason I call them Tosa mastiffs.

Three times their number was standard, and sometimes I'd brought back more than ten times as many monsters. After I'd shown them the threshold of hell a few times, a fierce glint had begun to burn in their eyes.

Of course, whenever things seemed genuinely dangerous, I stepped in from time to time even if I had been watching from the sidelines. Thanks to that, we had suffered injuries, but there had been no deaths.

After we repeated the process several times a day, I became both their common enemy and someone they trusted.

I don't want to go this far, but… I don't have a choice.

This was an intensive crash course. I needed to plant weeds capable of surviving harsh conditions in the Peace Guild's yard as quickly as possible.

In less than a month, several people had already given up and transferred to other teams. I hadn't tried to stop them, nor did I resent them for leaving.

The decision is theirs to make.

Everyone had a life of their own. I had only stepped into theirs for a little while.

I could present them with choices, but I had no right to force them to choose.

Ssshhhoooom!

As befitted an A-rank Gate, **Black Wizard's Black Forest** was vast.

But the area I had explored was only a tiny fraction of it. Keeping my pace under control, I soon saw the Gate entrance ahead.

"Here they come!"

"Jin Taekyung, you son of a bitch…"

"Still, maybe because it's their first time, he didn't bring that many."

"Gasp! Skeletons!"

Some loudly announced the monsters' arrival, while others cursed me or calmly assessed the enemy's numbers.

The greenhorns had no real combat experience yet, and I could see them shrinking back in fear.

Of course, the human Tosa mastiffs who had already experienced my brutal training weren't about to stand idle.

"What the fuck are you doing over there? The line's giving way!"

"Don't back up. Hold your shield tight. What? You need to piss? Then piss yourself!"

"New people, get a grip. That Jin Taekyung bastard isn't going to help you. He even started a charity foundation in advance because someone might die here!"

"…"

They were making me out to be complete trash.

It was absurd, but I held my tongue. Fine. That was what it took to snap the rookies out of their panic.

People badmouth even the king behind his back. What can you do?

Of course, I memorized every face.

As I approached the Hunters who had already formed their battle line, I sprang into the tallest tree and shouted,

“Shields together!”

Rumble!

Everyone moved in perfect unison.

Like dogs left staring up after the chicken they had been chasing, the undead monsters gazed toward the distant treetop before turning their grotesque faces away.

Then they spotted the more than fifty Hunters arrayed on the hill where the Gate entrance stood.

One of the skeletons raised its Bone Sword high and unleashed a hideous shriek.

—GRAAAAR!

It wasn’t an ordinary skeleton.

The bones that should have been exposed were wrapped in battered armor, and the Bone Sword raised as though to pierce the moon blazed with an ominous aura blacker than the night sky.

“A Skeleton Knight?”

Just because they were all skeletons didn’t mean they were all the same rank.

Skeleton Soldiers, Mages, Warriors…

Their abilities and strength varied wildly from one individual to the next, and Skeleton Knights were powerful monsters universally recognized as A-rank.

I’ve encountered them often in the Black Forest, but there’s something different about that one.

Encountering an A-rank monster like a Skeleton Knight inside an A-rank Gate was perfectly normal. They were stationed throughout the Black Forest, each commanding lower-level Warriors and Mages.

I narrowed my eyes and studied it.

Then—

—GRAAAH!

—GROOOAR!

Tss-tss-tss-tss!

Two more monstrous cries rang out, followed by two surging streams of aura.

I muttered in surprise,

“Three Skeleton Knights in one group?”

That was a first.

A skeleton horde was an army, and its knight was the general who led it. Every independent army had only one general.

Did three hordes form an alliance?

But my prediction was spectacularly wrong.

Rattling their bones, the two newly appeared knights approached the Skeleton Knight that had emerged first. They dropped to one knee and drove their Bone Swords into the ground.

It was an unmistakable act of submission.

Purple light flashed within the empty hollows where the first knight's eyes should have been.

Fwoooosh!

The light bursting from that abyssal darkness was intense.

The moment our gazes met, it erupted into blazing flame.

—GRAAAAR!

Krrrck!

The creature roared, and its body began to change.

Every bone grew thicker and longer, its surface gleaming with a strange black sheen.

The transformation didn't end there.

Shrrrraaaak!

Its armor, rusted and cracked in places, restored itself as though time were flowing backward. Broken chains reconnected, and the faded skull emblem on its chest regained its vivid color.

Finally, a dark green cloak fluttered in the wind.

Once the transformation was complete, the creature stared silently at its palm.

Instead of bare white bone, it saw a hand encased in a sturdy gauntlet.

And then—

"Not. Bad."

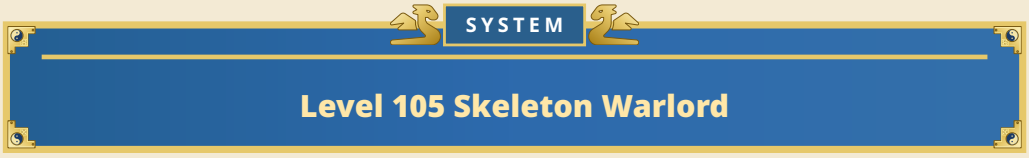
"..."

The air surrounding the forest trembled.

Everyone, myself included, stared at it in speechless silence.

A Skeleton Knight. A great knight reduced to a corrupted undead.

But it was no longer a Skeleton Knight.



“Come. Down. Hu. Man.”

Its blazing purple eyes fixed directly on me.

Chapter 295

Gleaming armor. A dark green cloak fluttering like wings. Purple ghost fire burning in empty eye sockets.

And then… there was a voice.

“Come. Down. Hu. Man.”

The moment I heard that metallic, scraping voice, I nearly fell out of the tree.

It spoke?

This wasn’t the first time something like this had happened. The Wyvern I’d killed in the past, “One-Eyed Carus,” had been capable of speech too.

But a monster speaking wasn’t something to take lightly.

“A Named Monster…”

The words escaped me like a groan.

That was right. As far as anyone knew, only Named Monsters were capable of speech.

And that very Named Monster had just been born before my eyes.

No—not born.

It had *evolved*.

Evolution?

I had never heard of or seen a Named Monster appearing this way before.

What is this, Digimon?[1555]

Wait, are monsters that kind of monster? They can evolve too?

I was already about five hundred light-years removed from an ordinary life, and even I was bewildered. The other Guild members’ reactions went without saying.

“What is that?”

“Wait, didn’t it just say something?”

“I’ve never seen anything like that, not even in a monster encyclopedia…”

Of course they hadn’t.

Named Monsters were mutants. Every individual possessed different traits and varied in strength. No one could know what one would be like until it appeared.

But why now, of all times?

I licked my dry lips.

[1555] Digimon is a Japanese media franchise in which creatures can evolve into more powerful forms.

I didn't know how powerful that Skeleton Warlord was, but it clearly possessed strength worthy of a Named Monster.

And on top of that, there are two A-rank Skeleton Knights.

The remaining hundred and fifty or so were all B-rank Skeleton Mages or Warriors. They were practically an army, which made them extremely troublesome.

Still, if I took on the Warlord and the two Knights—their commander and core fighting force—it was a battle we could win.

We've been raiding nonstop.

Only fifty Guild members had entered the Gate.

But more than half of them were Tosa mastiffs[1556] who had endured my whip and survived hellish special training.

They had fought so many Skeletons over the past week that they were sick of the sight of them. As long as they kept their heads, they could handle enemies two or three times their number.

And the new recruits are plenty capable too.

We paid salaries at least as high as the major Guilds, so we had selected only the best.

This time, I had personally taken part in multiple evaluations, including the interviews, and even scored their potential for growth.

To weather the typhoon that was Ares Guild, I had selected the finest saplings and transplanted them into the Peace Guild's front yard.

We'll have to accept some risk, but this is a fight worth taking on.

Team Leader Choi and the other three had suspended most of their Guild duties to focus entirely on training the Jin Family's cultivation technique.

The battle would have been much easier with them here, but even if they had been present, I wouldn't have sent them in.

A dagger hidden up one's sleeve was deadly precisely because it remained hidden. I couldn't reveal it with so many eyes watching.

Having reached a decision, I called out to one person.

"Jinsoo!"

"Yes, sir!"

Kim Jinsoo, who was effectively serving as deputy team leader, answered promptly. I pointed my dagger at the Skeleton Warlord.

The green ghost fire in its hollow eye sockets remained fixed on me.

"That's a Named Monster."

A sharp gasp rose from among the Guild members.

[1556] The Tosa is a Japanese fighting-dog breed. Taekyung uses "Tosa mastiffs" as a nickname for the experienced trainees.

Most of them had been Hunters for less than two years. A person could spend twenty years in this field without ever encountering a Named Monster, and now they had to fight one. The tension was plain on their faces.

But Kim Jinsoo was different. His surprise lasted only a moment before he calmly nodded.

“I see.”

“Oh? You’re doing a pretty good job pretending to be calm.”

“I’m a little shaken myself, but we can’t just stand around in a daze and let it kill us.”

Well, look at him.

I’d known from the beginning that he had guts, but this was unusual courage for someone in his first year.

Perhaps sensing my gaze, Kim Jinsoo smiled faintly and added, “If the situation were hopeless, you would’ve given the signal to retreat long ago. Am I right?”

“Hmm.”

“…Uh, did I get that wrong?”

“No.”

I chuckled and shook my head.

“You’re right. This is a fight we can take on.”

“Oh.”

“I’ll handle those three over there. You take the rest. How long can you hold out?”

Kim Jinsoo thought for a moment before answering.

“The new recruits don’t have much experience… but we should still be able to hold out for an hour.”

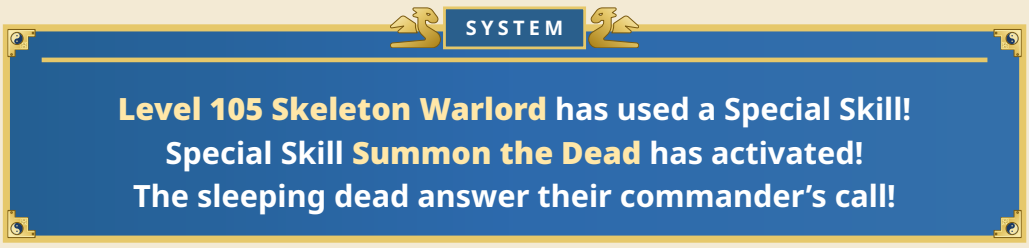
“An hour?”

“Yes. At least an hour.”

The instant Kim Jinsoo answered confidently, the Skeleton Warlord slowly opened its jaws and released a strange, indescribable resonance.

“GRAAAAAH!”

Beep!



It was a howl that sent a chill down my spine—and a cry that awakened the cursed dead.

Crack. Crack-crack-crack!

Soil burst upward, and the ground trembled. Piles of pale bones rose all around us, assembled themselves into skeletons, and joined the ranks.

Bone Swords caked with dirt. Wooden shields tangled with fine roots. Among the Skeleton Warriors, I could even see Mages wearing necklaces engraved with skulls.

There were even two more A-rank Skeleton Knights.

Adding the newcomers to the existing Skeleton army brought their numbers to well over three hundred.

"..."

"..."

I watched in silence for a moment before speaking.

"Jinsoo."

"Yes."

"Can you still do an hour?"

"Uh, well..."

"Be honest."

"...I think we can manage about thirty minutes."

"Really?"

"Yes. The situation has gotten a little worse, but we can probably do it."

Kim Jinsoo continued, staring uneasily at the Skeleton Warlord.

"As long as that bastard doesn't pull any more crap."

"I think it will."

"No way."

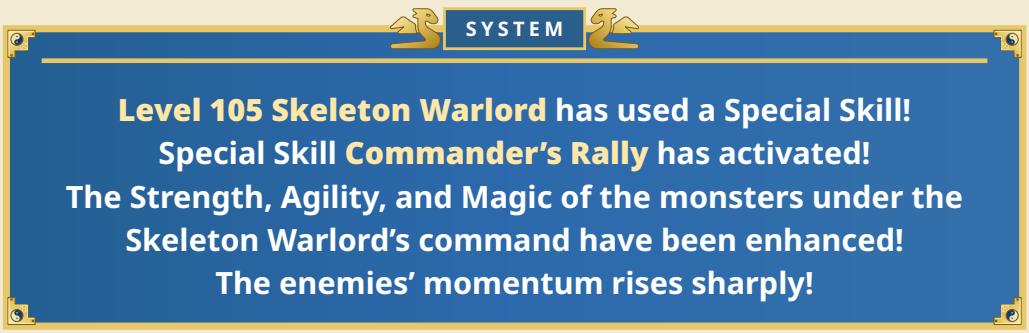
"GRAAAAAH!"

"See? I was right."

Kim Jinsoo groaned.

"Oh, come on."

Beep!



The Skeleton Warlord howled!

The effect was incredible!

“Wow…”

I activated Qi Sense and saw that every single one of them had gained five Levels.

The aura radiating from the Skeleton army of more than three hundred was on an entirely different level from before.

I glanced aside and found Kim Jinsoo staring blankly.

“Thirty minutes. Still possible?”

“…”

The bastard was cursing me with his eyes now.

To be fair, even I thought that was asking too much. Clicking my tongue, I gave my next order without hesitation.

“Fall back slowly. Don’t provoke them.”

“How far should we retreat?”

“To the path right in front of the Gate. Make sure we can get out at any time.”

“The path is narrow, so it should be easier to fight them there.”

“Exactly.”

As Kim Jinsoo had said, the path in front of the Gate was so narrow that five grown men could barely pass shoulder to shoulder.

Even Skeletons, whose frames were naturally thinner, could only fit seven or eight abreast.

However…

“Go straight out.”

There was no head-on battle in my revised plan.

“Huh?”

“Take the kids and get outside the Gate.”

Dismay spread across Kim Jinsoo’s face.

“Then what about you, Senior?”

“Do you think they’ll play tag while you leave? Someone has to buy time.”

“Senior! That’s dangerous!”

“Jinsoo. No—my dear Peace Guild members.”

I looked down solemnly. Fifty Guild members craned their necks like baby birds as they stared up at me.

“I—and the Peace Guild—always put the safety of our Guild members first.”

Several of the Tosa mastiffs[1557] muttered just loudly enough for me to hear.

“That’s the biggest load of bullshit I’ve heard all year.”

“I think I nearly died seven times this week.”

“More like ten for me.”

[1557]The Tosa is a Japanese fighting-dog breed. Taekyung uses “Tosa mastiffs” as a nickname for the experienced trainees.

Meanwhile, the eyes of the day-one pups trembled.

“Senior!”

“Ahh, Lord Fuck!”[1558]

“You’d go this far for us…!”

I continued in a voice thick with emotion.

“I’ll risk any danger for your safety. Even if my arm gets blown off! Even if my leg gets blown off! I will send every one of you back into the arms of those who love you!”

Several of them cried out in a surge of emotion.

“We can fight!”

“Please let us fight alongside you!”

I bit my lip hard and shook my head.

“I can’t! Someone has to make the sacrifice, and in a situation like this, I’m the best one to step forward!”

“But still…!”

Whoooosh! Shrrrk!

Before anyone could continue, an ominous black aura came hurtling toward us.

The Skeleton Warlord sliced horizontally through a massive tree dozens of meters tall[1559] and several meters around,[1560] then shouted in a voice like metal scraping against metal.

“I. Will. Kill. Every. Last. One. Of. You!”

Swish. Tap!

I leaped lightly from the tree and shouted, “Everyone, return to the Gate! I’ll cover the rear!”

This time, no one tried to stop me.

The army of more than three hundred Skeletons had begun to advance.

Clatter. Thud. Clatter. Thud.

The monsters marched in perfect ranks and files, their momentum utterly menacing.

The Warlord’s Special Skill had filled their steps with power, and faint lights flickered within their hollow skulls.

“GRAAAAH!”

When one of the Skeleton Knights, serving as a deputy commander, let out a fierce cry, rusted arrows and attack magic rose from the rear and shot toward the Peace Guild members.

[1558] “Lord Fuck” is an online nickname Taekyung acquired after accidentally swearing during a broadcast.

[1559] Dozens of meters is roughly dozens of yards; 20 meters is about 66 ft.

[1560] Several meters in circumference is roughly 10–30 ft.

Fwish-fwish-fwish! Whoooosh!

“Block them!”

“Tanks! Keep your shields up! Continue falling back slowly!”

“Covering fire!”

The two forces were about three hundred paces apart. To retreat safely, we needed to widen the distance further.

I swung White Flame and blocked the army’s advance.

“You bastards! How dare you threaten our precious Peace Guild members!”

Sssshhhk! Crack!

The power behind my spear shattered bone, while Spear Energy erupted from its transparent spearhead and slashed in every direction.

The moment I took down ten of them in a single blow, three Skeleton Knights charged me at once.

“GRAAAAH!”

“GRAAAAH!”

Sssshhhk!

Three streams of black aura narrowly grazed different parts of my body.

Blood trickled from my nape where the pressure had sliced it open, and anguished cries erupted from the Guild members who had already reached the narrow path.

“Aah! Senior!”

“Look out!”

Clang-clang-clang!

I deflected the relentless barrage of aura and shouted as if struggling to speak.

“Go! I’ll catch up soon!”

“But…!”

“Jinsoo! Get going!”

After a moment’s hesitation, Kim Jinsoo began leading the Guild members toward the Gate.

“You have to come back!”

I gave him a faint smile and nodded.

“Yeah.”

“I’m sorry, Senior!”

“It’s fine. Go!”

“Urgh!”

Kim Jinsoo hesitated until the very end, then disappeared beyond the Gate.

Now only the hundreds of Skeletons packed tightly into the narrow path and I remained.

“F. O. O. L. I. S. H.”

Clatter-clatter-clatter!

The bones parted like the Red Sea, and the Skeleton Warlord emerged through the opening.

“H. A. V. E. Y. O. U. R. E. S. I. G. N. E. D. Y. O. U. R. S. E. L. F. T. O. D. I. E, H. U. M. A. N?”

But I wasn’t listening.

Only after sweeping my gaze over every inch of our surroundings did I finally sigh in relief.

“Phew. They’re finally all gone.”

“…?”

“Those kids are way too sentimental for their own good. When the Team Leader tells you to leave, you’re supposed to run. What do they mean, help? Right?”

I wiped the blood from my nape. I’d tried to keep the cut shallow, but it was deeper than expected.

About 0.2 centimeters?[1561]

“Damn. What a waste of blood.”

The purple ghost fire in the Warlord’s eye sockets flickered uneasily.

“W. H. A. T. I. N. T. H. E. W. O. R. L. D. A. R. E. Y. O. U. P. L. O. T. T. I. N. G?”

“Nothing much.”

I smiled with satisfaction at the EXP—no, the Skeleton army—filling the narrow path without a single gap.

“You’re all going to die here. That’s all you need to know.”

“W. H. A. T?”

Instead of answering, I drew a deep breath.

The muscles throughout my body writhed, and the fire dragon coiled inside my dantian began to move according to the formula of the Fire Gate Divine Technique.

Then, in the next instant, I became one with the spear in my hand and shot forward.

“One Annihilation.”

KRAAAAAAASH!

[1561] 0.2 centimeters is about 0.08 in.

Chapter 296

How much time had passed?

He could no longer remember his name, his family, his friends or lover… He could not even remember where he had been born or what kind of life he had lived.

After passing through a long, deep darkness, he suddenly came to his senses and found himself in a forest.

Where is this?

The question lasted only a moment.

Soon, the instincts of a monster seized him, and he began fighting without purpose. He fought the humans who had once been his own kind, and he fought monsters as well.

An outstanding knight in life, he grew ever stronger as he cultivated his mana. Eventually, he even surpassed the black wizard who ruled the vast Black Forest and controlled every dead thing sleeping within it.

“Y-you bastard! How dare a mere Skeleton Knight…!”

“GRAAAAAH!”

Crack!

Thus, the fallen knight became the new master of the Black Forest.

And at last, he rose to become a chosen being.

Commander of the Skeleton army.

Skeleton Warlord was his new name.

So this is what it feels like?

It was astonishing. Everything around him had changed. He did not know why, but the mana flowing through the Black Forest had grown denser, and immense power surged through his body despite it being nothing more than bones.

To him, newly reborn as something else, a mere handful of humans was utterly insignificant.

There aren’t many of them, and they’re all terrified.

To humans, death was simply another name for fear.

Now that he was already one of the dead, the humans’ terror was nothing but amusing.

Run. Then bring me more—more lives!

He was now the master of the Black Forest and commander of the dead.

The larger groups of humans they brought would soon become his soldiers. Once he commanded thousands, tens of thousands of the dead…

The Black Forest would no longer be enough for him.

Only then could he be reborn not as a mere commander of the dead, but as a true lord.

I will leave this place and conquer a wider territory.

That was when, as he watched the fifty or so humans flee in panic with satisfaction, one of them caught his eye.

That one…

A human surrounded by three Skeleton Knights, frantically exchanging blows with them.

Strangely enough, unlike the other humans who spoke in a bizarre language, he could understand every word that came from this one's mouth.

"I'm fine! Hurry up and go!"

How was this possible? Such fluent command of the Demon Realm language.

Was he perhaps a monster in human form?

He knew nothing of the System applied to Jin Taekyung, much less the function of the Integrated Language Pack.

He simply wanted to turn that one—who seemed useful enough for a human—into one of the dead and take him as a subordinate.

"F. O. O. L. I. S. H. H. U. M. A. N."

But he should have known.

The foolish one was himself.

"Phew. They're finally all gone."

"…?"

He should never have led his entire army into this narrow path.

"You're all going to fucking die here. That's all you need to know."

"W. H. A. T?"

He soon learned the answer to his question.

"One Annihilation."

Whoooosh!

The moment a vortex wreathed in blue flame erupted into the air, fear crept over the Skeleton Warlord.

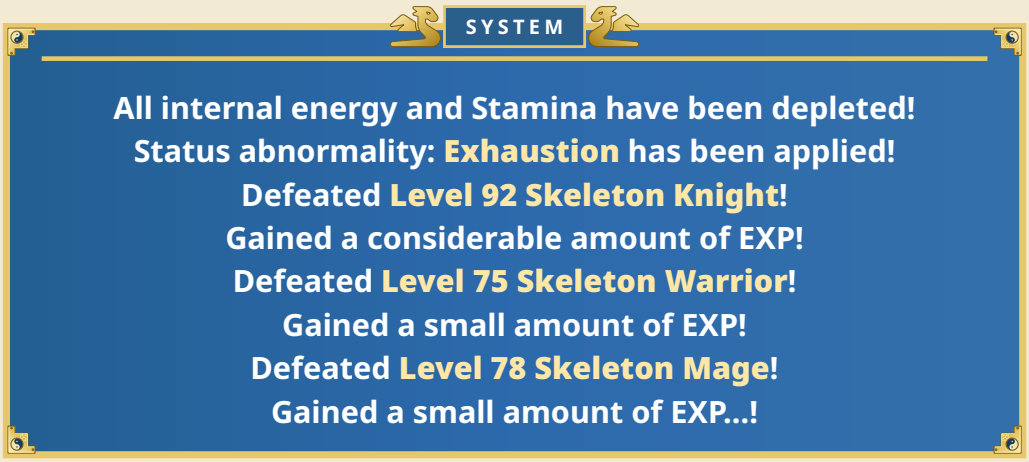
It was an emotion he had forgotten long ago—the fear of death, which had become more a friend than something to dread.

"E. V. E. R. Y. O. N. E. D. O. D. G. E—!"

The Warlord could not finish speaking.

Blue flames swept through the narrow path, engulfing him and hundreds of Skeletons.

KRAAAAAAASH!



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Beep. Beep. Beep.

The System notifications drilled endlessly into my ears.

My vision spun, and my legs buckled.

I had never imagined the spear shaft in my hand could feel this heavy.

As the spearhead slowly sank toward the ground, I barely managed to drive it into the earth and use it to support myself.

Fuck, I'm dying.

One Annihilation was the only—and strongest—skill I possessed. It used internal energy and Stamina as fuel to unleash more explosive power than anything else.

Unlike the first time, my rising martial arts realm now allowed me to control how much force I put into it. But the aftermath was still devastating.

One Annihilation is as dangerous as it is destructive. I won't survive long if I keep thinking in terms of all or nothing.

The best choice was to achieve the greatest result with the least amount of power.

As someone who always pursued efficient combat, I could not afford to use One Annihilation recklessly. A final move meant that if it failed, there would be no next move.

But this time was different.

If I don't use it now, when will I get another chance?

A narrow path. Hundreds of monsters packed together without a single gap.

It was practically a stage built for One Annihilation.

I had exhausted my full strength and fallen into the **Exhaustion** status, but there was a contingency for every action.

Beep.

The notification I had been waiting for sounded, and a refreshing sensation swept through my entire body.

Whoooosh.

The dantian that had been emptied by the aftermath of One Annihilation filled once more, and strength returned to my trembling limbs.

Only then did my whitened vision clear, allowing me to see the results of One Annihilation.

“Wow…”

I had expected something like this, but the reality was beyond anything I had imagined.

I marveled at the sight spread out before me.

Crackle. Crackle-crackle.

The force of One Annihilation had widened the narrow path to twice its original width.

The enormous trees and rocks that had surrounded it had been uprooted, and piles of bones engulfed in flames slowly burned across the blackened ground.

How many did I send straight to the grave in one shot?

There were still some that were breathing—

No. They were undead monsters, so they were already dead. I should say *still moving*.

In any case, fewer than fifty remained. Even those were practically incapable of fighting.

Did I kill… about three hundred?

Now I understood why the System had called it a massacre.

Of course, compared to that grand choice of words, the EXP it gave me was absolutely pathetic.

“What’s the point of leveling up only once? So stingy.”

Clicking my tongue, I began finishing off the remaining Skeletons.

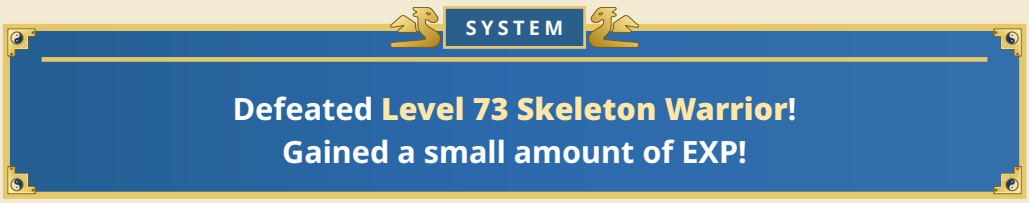
Every little bit added up. With the EXP required for each level rising like a mountain, every single trash mob mattered.

“Kreeeek. Krik.”

Crack!

I crushed the skull of a Skeleton crawling along with both legs missing.

Beep.



Damn. The EXP really was stingy.

I grumbled as I turned my head to search for the next monster.

“Oh. Ohhh. Could that be…!”

Then my eyes flew open, and a warm feeling spread through one corner of my chest.

Heart pounding with excitement, I approached the creature buried in a mound of dirt.

A Skeleton, trembling with only its head remaining.

The green ghost fire that had once blazed like a torch had shriveled to a tiny flame, like a candle flickering in the wind. But it was still enough for me to identify him.

Level 105 Skeleton Warlord

I smiled broadly and waved at the skull.

“Nice to meet you, friend!”

“…”

“You were here! Why didn’t you say so sooner? Why were you just sitting there?”

“Krik. Kreeeek?”

Look at this sly bastard, pretending to be a Skeleton Warrior.

Feigning disappointment, I raised the spearhead.

“Ah, what? You were just a trash mob. I guess I’ll kill you.”

“W. A. I. T!”

“Whoa. It can talk. Could it be…?”

“Y. E. S. That. Is. Right. It. Is. I.”

The Skeleton Warlord opened its eyes wide and continued.

“Master. Of. The. Black. Forest. Commander. Who. Leads. The. Dead. This. Body. Is. The. Warlord.”

“Wow! Warlord!”

“Only. Now. Do. You. Recognize. Me?”

“Wow! EXP!”

“…W. H. A. T?”

Sensing something was wrong, the Warlord hurriedly continued.

“Surely you do not intend to kill me?”

This bastard… Look how smoothly he talks now that he's desperate.

"Who said anything about killing? You're already dead."

"Could this body not die and die again, a hundred times over?"

"…Are you Jeong Mong-ju?"[1562]

Has this guy actually read the Song of My Single Heart?

When I stared at him in disbelief, the Warlord clacked his jaw.

"Human. Instead. Of. This. Why. Do. You. Not. Make. A. Deal. With. Me?"

"A deal?"

"That. Is. Right. I. Can. Give. You. Many. Things."

"You make the first offer."

"Make. The. First. Offer? What. Does. That. Mean?"

"List what you can give me. I'll listen and decide."

The Warlord fell silent for a moment as though deep in thought, then answered.

"I. Am. The. Ruler. Of. The. Forest. I. Shall. Bestow. This. Vast. Black. Forest. Upon. You!"

"The Black Forest is ours."

"…?"

"We have exclusive rights to the Gate, so it doesn't matter."

"Exclusive. Rights. To. The. Gate? I. Do. Not. Know. What. That. Is. But. Becoming. The. Ruler. Of. The. Forest. Would. Be. Far. Better!"

"No, it wouldn't. I'd much rather come here whenever the monsters respawn, round them all up, and farm them."

"R-round. Us. Up? How. Dare. A. Mere. Human. Hunt. Us!"

"Yeah. I'm thinking of sending one more on its way right now."

Crack.

When I tightened my grip around his skull, the Warlord's jaw trembled violently, and he shouted in panic.

"Wait! Wait! I. Just. Heard. A. Strange. Sound!"

"Come to think of it, you don't even have a cochlea. How can you hear anything? What a fascinating creature."

"There. Is. A. Crack. In. The. Crown. Of. My. Skull! If. This. Continues. I. Will. Be. Erased!"

"Wow! Fucking sweet EXP!"

"You. Insolent. Wretch! I. Am. The. Ruler. Of. The. Black. Forest. And. The. Commander. Of. The. Dead—"

Crack!

[1562] Jeong Mong-ju was a fourteenth-century Korean scholar-official remembered for *Dansimga*, or "Song of My Single Heart," a poem about unwavering loyalty.

“O. Ruler. Of. The. Black. Forest! O. Lord. Of. The. Dead! Please. Show. Mercy!”

“…”

That turnaround was Hyuk Mujin-tier at the very least.

Having such a long conversation with a monster was certainly novel, but it was time to stop playing around.

“Inventory open. Summon dagger.”

Shing.

When I held the dark-blue blade in front of his eyes, the Warlord asked anxiously,

“W-what are you going to do, sir?”

“Huh? Nothing much. Close your eyes and stay still. It’ll be over soon.”

“O-over? What do you mean?”

“Shh. Keep your jaw still. If even a bone gets cut, the resale value will drop.”

The corpse of the Wyvern I had killed before, One-Eyed Carus, had been worth its weight in gold. But I had no idea which parts of this Skeleton would be valuable.

Still, a Named Monster’s skull ought to sell for a pretty penny as a decoration, right?

A prize was still a prize. The surface of his bones gleamed with a black sheen and was actually rather beautiful.

I planned to erase him for good first, then gather up the bones nearby.

“Wait! Please, wait!”

Clack! Clack-clack-clack-clack!

God, this guy was noisy.

Just as I was about to grab the Warlord’s jaw, which kept jerking up and down without pause, he shouted.

“E-EXP! I will give you EXP!”

“Huh? I’m already here to collect it, so will you stay still? Besides, you don’t even know what EXP is.”

“No! I will give it to you! I will have my subordinates find it and bring it to you somehow!”

“What the hell are you talking about? EXP isn’t an item…”

I stopped speaking.

A thought had flashed through my mind.

Could this actually work?

“You said you were the master of the Black Forest, right?”

“Y-yes. Yes, yes!”

“How many subordinates do you have?”

“All! All of them! Not right away, but if I search the Black Forest, I can summon more than a thousand!”

“A thousand?”

“More than a thousand at the bare minimum! Have you forgotten who I am?”

“A Skeleton Warlord.”

“Y-yes. No soldier can defy its commander. The lesser creatures would never dare oppose me!”

“Hmm.”

“I will find whatever you want, even if I have to scour the entire Black Forest—or turn it upside down!”

I organized my thoughts as I gazed into the green ghost fire flickering desperately in his eyes.

The deliberation did not last long.

“Hey.”

“Yes.”

“Let’s work together on a job.”

“What kind of job…?”

“Something like that. You just have to do what I tell you.”

At my sinister smile, the Warlord’s skull began to tremble.

Chapter 297

Inhale. Exhale.

Choi Minwoo took a long, deep breath.

As he accepted the qi permeating the air, he awakened the mass of qi sleeping in his lower abdomen.

Mana.

The source of an Awakened's power. Their greatest weapon against monsters.

But Jin Taekyung, the man who had taught him the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, called mana by another name.

Internal energy.

The more Choi Minwoo saw of Jin Taekyung, the more mysterious the man seemed. He turned ideas no one else would have dared imagine into reality—and made them work.

There was no way anything taught by such a man could be ordinary.

Dantian, internal energy, circulating one's qi, the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique…

Each new side of Jin Taekyung came as a surprise, but this time, Minwoo was downright bewildered.

He taught me the Mana Cultivation Method as if it were nothing.

Choi Minwoo knew how extraordinary the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was.

No. Any Hunter—or even an ordinary person with the slightest knowledge of the field—would recognize its value at once.

If a Hunter was a sword, the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was a whetstone.

Even the dullest blade could be honed sharp.

Considering both the technique's effectiveness and its rarity…

Its value would quite literally be astronomical.

The sheer nerve it takes to casually hand over such an incredible secret art. The skill to defeat a Named Monster alone. The courage to stand his ground against Lee Jungryong and the Ares Guild… Is there anyone else like him?

With each passing day, Choi Minwoo realized more clearly just how remarkable Jin Taekyung was.

And how incredibly lucky he himself was.

I can't disappoint him.

That was why Choi Minwoo devoted himself to practicing the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, even cutting into his sleep.

And the results were already beginning to show.

Swoooosh.

After spending so long circulating his qi that he lost all track of time, the immense energy passed through hundreds of acupoints and swelled ever so slightly.

Only a week ago, he had not even known it existed.

For a moment, the conversation he had shared with Jin Taekyung that day flashed through Choi Minwoo's mind.

"Wow, Team Leader."

"Yes?"

"Did you happen to eat anything special when you were young? Ginseng, maybe, or one of those round pills?"

"Not at all. My meals were always organic, but I never took anything separately."

"And I bet you've never caught so much as a common cold, from childhood until now. Am I right?"

"That is correct. How did you know?"

"Your muscles and bones… No, I mean, your body is exceptionally well-built."

"Is that so? But wouldn't that be true of any Hunter?"

"It's not because you're a Hunter. You were born with an outstanding physique. My guess is that your grandfather did something for you."

"My grandfather…?"

"Yes. Does anything come to mind?"

"I'm not sure. I was too young to remember much. Butler Kim told me that my grandfather came to see me occasionally, but… that's all."

"Hmm. Personally, that seems like the only possible explanation."

Choi Minwoo suddenly thought of his grandfather. Had the last time he saw him been before he started elementary school?

The face in his memory was blurry, while the photographs online were crystal clear. By any measure, they had been far from a close grandfather and grandson.

But if such a huge mass of energy had been hidden inside me… Could my grandfather really have done something?

The unexpected trace of his grandfather made Choi Minwoo's heart pound.

As if responding to him, the energy coursing through his body shuddered.

The enormous power Jin Taekyung called *one jiazi*[1563] made one final sweeping circuit, then settled gently into the dantian beneath his navel.

At that moment, Choi Minwoo opened his eyes as an electric thrill ran through him.

"Phew."

The lingering afterglow of circulating his qi escaped with his long exhalation.

[1563] *Jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here as a unit of internal energy.

Choi Minwoo did not know it, but he had just reached Four Stars in the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique. It was an astonishingly rapid achievement, almost impossible to believe after only a week.

Yet it had been possible because Choi Minwoo possessed one jiazi[1564] of immense internal energy and such exceptional Muscles and Bones that even Jin Taekyung had nodded in approval.

The others aren't finished yet.

Choi Minwoo looked around and saw three people still absorbed in circulating their qi.

Seated at regular intervals around the room were Butler Kim, Song Song, and Im Kkeokjeong.

The fact that all four of them were learning the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique was the strictest of secrets.

They were currently inside Choi Minwoo's private training room, protected by ironclad security.

I shouldn't disturb them.

Jin Taekyung had warned him about the dangers of qi deviation until he was sick of hearing it.

Choi Minwoo slipped out of the training room as carefully as possible, then picked up the phone he had switched off earlier.

Less than a minute later, his jaw dropped.

Breaking-news alerts were updating across the screen at a blinding pace.

- The return of a Named Monster! Korea in crisis!
- An anomaly at the A-rank Gate, Black Wizard's Black Forest.
- Jin Taekyung volunteers as bait. Witness testimonies: "He possesses a noble spirit of sacrifice." "A Benefactor I will never forget."
- Hunter Association formulating a response and preparing to dispatch a rescue team.
- Peace Guild representative: "We are currently unable to reach the leadership…"
- Netizens unleash criticism over the Association's sluggish response. Jin Taekyung has been isolated for twenty minutes.
- Will a miracle occur?

"W-what is this?"

What did they mean, sacrifice? And what was this about being isolated?

Jin Taekyung was supposed to be clearing the Gate with his Guild members. How had that turned into a sacrifice?

And where had this Named Monster suddenly come from?

Choi Minwoo stood frozen, eyes wide, before hurriedly pulling himself together.

[1564] *Jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here as a unit of internal energy.

This isn't the time to stand around.

He knew Jin Taekyung's abilities well.

But if Taekyung had volunteered as bait and sent the Guild members out ahead of him, then he had to be facing an overwhelming threat.

This is… really dangerous.

Just as Choi Minwoo gripped his phone hard enough to crush it, the tightly shut door of the training room opened and three people emerged.

"Ah, that feels refreshing."

"Uncle, doesn't my skin look better?"

"Ah, Young Master. You were already out—"

"Butler Kim!"

One urgent shout was enough.

The three of them immediately sensed that something serious had happened, and their faces hardened.

Butler Kim calmly asked, "What happened?"

"We have to get to Jin Taekyung. Right now!"

The entrance to the A-rank Gate, Black Wizard's Black Forest, was already swarming with people.

Hunters from the Association and other Guilds had been dispatched to secure the area. Reporters had even risked their lives for a scoop.

The voices of hundreds upon hundreds of people filled the area with a constant murmur.

"Do you think Jin Taekyung is dead?"

"His chances aren't good. We haven't heard a thing for an hour."

"But he's already taken down a Named Monster once…"

"Ah, that Wyvern? Impressive, sure. Very impressive, but…"

The senior reporter speaking with his junior tapped the ash from his cigarette.

"If you're going to call yourself a Hunter beat reporter, then use your head. Didn't you hear the interview with the Peace Guild members who were with Jin Taekyung? There wasn't just a Named Monster. They said there were hundreds of other monsters too. That changes everything."

"Is it really that bad?"

"Hey, the only reason things have gotten this far is because it's Jin Taekyung. If it were anyone else, we wouldn't even be saying things like 'probably' or 'it's difficult.' What Hunter do you think could hold out alone for an hour? Rescue preparations, my ass. They'd already be preparing to recover his body."

The junior reporter let out a low groan.

“So it’s really that bad.”

“It’s completely fucked. And we’re insane too, hanging around here trying to scribble out an article in the middle of all this.”

“Still, they wouldn’t have allowed us to cover it if they couldn’t guarantee some degree of safety, right?”

“Can’t you see them over there? More than thirty A-rank Hunters showed up.”

The senior reporter gestured with his chin toward several dozen Hunters who looked formidable even at a glance.

The ones who stood out most wore emblems of a crossed sword and shield on their chests.

“The Ares Guild sent people too.”

“They only just arrived. Those bastards will blow off even the government if they don’t like the odds… No idea what brought them here.”

“Do you think they came to rescue Jin Taekyung?”

“Who knows? Maybe. Or maybe they’re planning to claim the Named Monster for themselves.”

Named Monsters were worth an unbelievable amount.

Even One-Eyed Carus, the Wyvern Jin Taekyung had most recently killed, had been valued in the trillions of won[1565] despite having only just awakened as a Named Monster.

“But… shouldn’t the rescue operation be starting by now? We have enough firepower.”

“We do. But I doubt those guys see it that way.”

“What?”

“Never mind. Forget it.”

The senior reporter fell silent.

He had spent nearly twenty years in the field and was a veteran among veterans. He had eyes and ears everywhere, and he had seen and heard plenty over the years.

Jin Taekyung must have gotten on their nerves.

He had recently heard some strange news from a reliable source.

There were signs of unusual tension between the Myeongdong and Peace Guilds.

Only a handful of people knew about it, and the story had quickly died down as idle gossip. But the instincts he had honed over many years whispered that something was going on.

And now the Ares Guild shows up.

[1565] One trillion won is about $710 million or €650 million; “trillions of won” indicates a value at least that large.

There was nothing strange about Korea's largest Guild stepping forward when a Named Monster appeared.

Still, something felt wrong. It was an uneasiness he could not put into words.

The reporter was looking toward the assembled leadership when he suddenly frowned.

You're going to rub your palms raw, you idiot.

The Seoul Branch President, who could be considered the person in overall charge of this operation, was busily rubbing his palms in front of a man who looked to be in his thirties.

What was that guy's name again? Plaster statue? Go Jun?[1566]

He was supposedly the Ares Guild's security team leader—the right-hand man of Lee Jungryong, the Guild's de facto Guild Master.

Watching the Seoul Branch President fawn over him as though he would gladly cut out his own liver for the man, the reporter began to understand why the rescue operation was being delayed.

"These bastards sure are having fun."

That was what the Senior reporter muttered in a voice barely loud enough to hear before grinding out his half-smoked cigarette.

"The Peace Guild!"

"What? Where?"

"Hey, hey! Get the cameras ready!"

The crowd erupted into commotion. Broadcasting crews shouted, and every eye turned in the same direction.

Four people.

Three men and one woman carved a path through the crowd as though parting the Red Sea. They made it all the way to the Gate before Hunters from the Seoul Branch moved to stop them.

"Get out of our way."

Choi Minwoo stood at the front, his voice low and steady. The Seoul Branch President hurried over to answer him.

"Safety has not yet been confirmed. We need more time before we can begin the rescue operation…"

"More time? Here?"

"Just a little longer. A little longer will be enough."

"Nearly an hour has already passed."

His voice remained calm, but flames flickered in his eyes. The three people behind him looked no different.

[1566] In Korean, the reporter confuses Go Jun's full name with the phrase for "plaster statue," a wordplay that English cannot reproduce directly.

“We have to save him now.”

“Not yet. Follow procedure.”

“Whose procedure? The Association’s? Or…”

For one brief moment, Choi Minwoo’s gaze swept over Go Jun, who stood behind the Association president.

He clenched his lips, then continued.

“Pull back the Association’s Hunters. The Peace Guild will enter on its own.”

“You must know that would violate regulations.”

The president answered in an authoritative tone and snapped his fingers.

The Seoul Association’s Hunters surrounded the Peace Guild members, open reluctance on their faces.

“It won’t take much longer. Be patient and wait.”

Those words snapped the last thread of Choi Minwoo’s patience.

He shouted as if spitting out a ball of fire.

“My friend is in there!”

Click! Flash!

Cameras captured the scene as dazzling flashes burst all around him.

Choi Minwoo paid them no attention. He continued shouting, his voice thick with fury.

“He could die! We have to save him!”

When he thought of Jin Taekyung fighting for his life against a Named Monster leading an army of hundreds of Skeletons, his anger erupted like an active volcano.

“Get the fuck out of the way, you bastards!”

The Skeleton Warlord spoke in a majestic voice.

“In the commander’s name, I order you. Rise, my loyal subordinates. Mighty soldiers of my legion!”

At that moment, someone smacked the Warlord’s skull with lightning-fast hands.

Whack!

“For fuck’s sake. Why does your incantation have to be so goddamn long? I told you to make it quick.”

“…”

“No answer?”

“…Yessir.”

The Warlord muttered in a resigned voice.

“Come on, grow. Skeletons, skeletons…”

Whoooosh!

Demonic qi burst from the Warlord and spread through the Black Forest.

A bright smile appeared on the young man’s lips as he watched Skeletons spring up one after another from the clearing.

“Wow. Another bumper harvest.”

Chapter 298

“Come on, grow. Skeletons, skeletons…”

Beep!

SYSTEM

Lv. 105 Skeleton Warlord has used a special Skill!
Special Skill, Summon the Dead, has been activated!
The sleeping dead answer the Commander’s call!

I had never felt so at ease.

Every time I watched a Skeleton shoot up like a bean sprout, happiness welled up inside me.

Is this how farmers feel?

What a bumper crop. What a harvest.

I beamed and swung my sickle—no, my spear—and began reaping.

Every time I smashed the skull of a Skeleton that had only just awakened, a beautiful sound rang out.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 71 Skeleton Warrior!
You have gained a small amount of EXP!
You have defeated Lv. 70 Skeleton Archer!
You have gained a small amount of EXP!

The Skeleton Warlord, now forced to offer up his subordinates as EXP, muttered sorrowfully.

“Ah, my soldiers. Forgive your disloyal commander. To fall prey to the schemes of a wicked human and be erased before you could demonstrate your true strength…”

I was about to swing my spear at the next one when I suddenly stopped.

“What did you just say?”

“I called you a wicked human!”

Well, look at this guy.

He was supposed to be groveling, yet here he was glaring at me and talking back. Apparently, his fury at being demoted from commander of the great undead army to EXP factory manager had overcome his fear of Erasure.

“I would rather be erased than offer my soldiers to you!”

“Whether you get erased is for me to decide. More importantly, repeat what you said before that.”

“Wicked human!”

“Not that.”

“Not that? Then what?”

“You said they didn’t get to show their true strength, right?”

“…What of it?”

“Come to think of it, you have some weird Skill. Commander’s Rally, or whatever it was.”

“H-how do you know about that?!”

“Oh, right. No wonder something felt off. I forgot all about it.”

I beamed and stroked the Warlord’s skull.

“Use it.”

The Warlord asked again, sounding genuinely baffled.

“Commander’s Rally? Why?”

“The buff raises their Levels. I need to squeeze every last bit of EXP out of them.”

“…!”

“So hurry up and use it. If you do a good job, I might even let you go.”

“R-really?”

“There’s a saying in the human world: a man’s word is worth a thousand pieces of gold. It means a man always keeps his word.”

“A man who lost his mama is worth a thousand pieces of gold? What a strange saying.”

“Why would he lose his mama? Making mom jokes now, you fucking bastard? Maybe I should just erase you.”

Crack.

When I tightened my grip around his head, the Skeleton Warlord cried out in alarm.

“Wait! My bone—it’s cracking! My bone!”

“Lord, I’m sending one up.”

“Wait!”

“So are you going to do it or not?”

The Warlord’s green pupils darted anxiously from side to side.

For a Skeleton, he displayed a surprisingly wide range of emotions. After a moment, he finally forced out an answer.

“I-I’ll do it.”

“Good choice.”

“But do not misunderstand. This is not submission. It is a contract!”

"A contract?"

"That is right! Not obedience, but a contract mutually agreed upon by both parties!"

"…This bastard is more human than I am, and he's a Skeleton. So what are the terms?"

"In exchange for cooperating with you, wicked human, you will guarantee my current position."

"The master of the Black Forest and commander of the undead army?"

"Correct! In addition, cease this indiscriminate and barbaric slaughter!"

"…"

What had I just heard?

A monster, of all things, had just told me to stop my indiscriminate and barbaric slaughter. My head spun for a moment.

"Are you out of your mind? Is that something a monster should be saying?"

"How insulting. I am a Skeleton Warlord possessed of cool judgment and intelligence. Though I may have become one of the fallen undead, the spirit of chivalry remains engraved deep within my soul."

"…If you had upheld chivalry, you wouldn't have fallen like this in the first place."

"…The truth is, my memories of life were erased when I became undead."

"Then don't go on about chivalry. You're a real piece of work."

Still, perhaps because he was a Named Monster, he was clearly different from ordinary monsters that were ruled by instinct and did nothing but howl.

Anyway, a contract.

I considered it carefully, then finally spoke.

"Fine. I've decided."

"Human. Will you accept my contract?"

"No. I don't want to."

"…Huh?"

I continued as the green light in his eyes quivered with confusion.

"I'm okay with the first proposal. You can be the master of the Black Forest and the commander of the army, or whatever. But…"

"But?"

"From now on, you're the Peace Guild's EXP factory manager. In exchange for guaranteeing your position, you'll supply me with as many Skeletons as I want."

"That is absurd!"

"Don't like it?"

"I would rather be erased than become a human puppet!"

"Your wish has been received, valued customer."

Crack.

The Skeleton Warlord, a crack running across the crown of his skull, answered in a solemn voice.

“On second thought, it is not such a bad contract.”

“…”

“A commander cannot abandon his soldiers. Human, as master of the Black Forest and commander of the undead army, I accept your proposal.”

“You just said you’d rather be erased than become a human puppet.”

“An army falls apart without its commander. Do not misunderstand. I am merely enduring a moment of humiliation for the sake of the soldiers waiting for me.”

“But those are the very soldiers you have to offer up.”

“I will remember their noble sacrifice until the day I am erased. So, how much is this month’s tribute? No—how many troops must I offer?”

“…”

Look at him, giving them away without holding back since he wasn’t the one being destroyed.

At this point, he wasn’t a puppet. He was a snail bride.[1567]

When I stared at him with an utterly dumbfounded expression, the world’s first pro-human Named Monster, the Skeleton Warlord, hurriedly began chanting.

“Grow stronger, Skeletons, Skeletons!”

Beep!

SYSTEM

Lv. 105 Skeleton Warlord has used a special Skill!
Special Skill, Commander’s Rally, has been activated!
The Strength, Agility, and Magic of the monsters under the Skeleton Warlord’s command have been enhanced!
The enemies’ Levels have increased by 5!

…He can do it all by himself now.

The harvesting was easy.

The first time was the hard part. After two or three repetitions, I got the hang of it.

The Skeleton Warlord made full use of his abilities as a commander to gather the tribute troops as quickly as possible.

[1567] A snail bride is a figure from a Korean folktale: a mysterious spirit who secretly performs household chores for a poor man.

“Legion! Assemble!”

Clatter, clatter!

Around a hundred freshly sprouted Skeletons gathered in one place. All I had to do was unleash Spear Energy at the monsters assembled under his command, and EXP came raining down.

Swoooosh! Boom!

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The sound of EXP rolling in brought a smile to my face. As he watched, the Warlord muttered in satisfaction.

“Hmm. This is much faster and easier.”

“…”

“Human. Have you witnessed my command ability? This is the majesty of a commander.”

What a pro-human bastard.

Watching him take pride in devising a more efficient way to offer up his soldiers, I felt like I finally understood why his soul had become corrupted.

If the winds of liberation[1568] ever swept through the Black Forest, the Skeleton independence fighters would put him at the very top of their purge list.

Why do I feel like I’m the invader here?

Feeling strangely conflicted, I began collecting the loot.

Skeletons were one of the most dirt-poor monster species around. Their so-called by-products were either rusty weapons that could cause tetanus or half-rotted bones.

You could at least get beef and bone broth from a Minotaur carcass. Apparently, no matter how long you simmered Skeleton bones, all you got was the taste of a grave.

“Oh, a Magic Gem and some armor.”

At least Skeleton Knights, which appeared about as often as beans in a drought, sometimes left behind one or two Magic Gems and decent pieces of Equipment like these.

Of course, even that only happened once in a blue moon.

“A Magic Gem this size should easily fetch tens of millions of won.[1569]”

Sending the Guild members away had been the right call. I got to monopolize both the EXP and the Magic Gems—the best of both worlds.

As I happily pocketed a Magic Gem the size of an adult’s fist, the Warlord asked me a question.

[1568] The Korean word *gwangbok* refers to Korea’s liberation from Japanese colonial rule in 1945. Here, the narrator imagines the Skeletons liberating themselves.

[1569] “Tens of millions of won” suggests roughly 20–90 million won, or about $14,000–$64,000 and €13,000–€58,000.

“Wicked human. What are you doing?”

“Can’t you tell? Collecting the fruits of my labor.”

“Do you intend to absorb it later?”

“Absorb it? Don’t be ridiculous. Of course I’m going to sell it.”

“Foolish. Magic Gems are the source of power. Is it not only natural to eat them and grow stronger?”

“That’s something monsters like you do. Humans are different.”

It was common knowledge that humans weren’t monsters’ only enemies.

Monsters often fought among themselves, and some grew stronger by devouring the monsters they defeated.

“Is that so? Humans are truly an incomprehensible race. You could grow stronger by absorbing Magic Gems… Is this thing called money really so wonderful?”

“We need money to live whether we like it or not. Besides, humans can’t absorb Magic Gems.”

The energy contained within Magic Gems was commonly known as demonic qi. It was the foundation of a monster’s strength, but to humans, it was no different from poison.

It was a type of qi, but the easiest way to understand it was to think of it as a contaminant.

After I gave him a rough explanation, the Warlord tilted his skull.

“You cannot absorb it? How strange. A group of humans I encountered long ago used Troll blood to heal their bodies.”

“Ah, potions? That goes through a purification process…”

“Then why not purify Magic Gems as well? Just as you do with the Troll blood you call potions.”

“If it were that simple, we’d have purified them long ago. You really are simpleminded, just like a monster.”

If Troll blood was a fruit-flavored drink with one percent fruit flavoring, a Magic Gem was one hundred percent fresh fruit juice.

People couldn’t even remove all the toxicity from potions, yet he was suggesting we absorb Magic Gems.

I let out a short laugh and continued.

“Anyway, humans can’t absorb Magic Gems.”

“Why?”

“Stop asking questions, you question-mark murderer. That’s the established academic consensus. I’ve never heard or seen anything like that.”

“I have never heard of a human like you, either.”

I was about to smack the Warlord’s skull when I stopped.

Wait. He has a point.

There's no need to be bound by common sense all the time.

Wasn't I living proof that common sense didn't apply to everything?

Even the so-called accepted academic consensus was only a conclusion based on what people currently knew.

The Mana Cultivation Method is the same.

Only a tiny handful of people knew it existed.

I hadn't even considered that before getting tangled up with the Ares Guild.

Their private league had remained unchanged both before and after the appearance of monsters, and its secrets had always been shared only within the boundaries they had drawn.

Absorbing a Magic Gem…

Should I give it a try?

Just as I was about to open my Inventory and take out the Magic Gem again, the Warlord spoke.

"Heh heh. You look as though you have just been struck. Wicked and foolish human."

"Oh. Want me to hit your skull with an Erasure Punch?"

"…That was a rash remark. I apologize."

"You apologized within three seconds, so I'll allow it."

Having escaped Erasure by observing the universal three-second rule, the Skeleton Warlord muttered,

"There is no greater humiliation. Consider yourself fortunate that I have not grown stronger, human."

"You started as a Skeleton Knight and became master of the Black Forest through a coup. I'd say you've risen pretty far."

"I am a Warlord now! Master of the Black Forest and—"

"Commander of the undead army. Yeah, yeah. I'm getting calluses on my ears from hearing it."

I only learned later that he had taken over the Black Forest.

He had defeated the black wizard, who had practically been its true master. He must have absorbed an incredible number of Magic Gems.

"So this is a complete human—or rather, Skeleton—victory. Going from an ordinary Skeleton Knight to the master of the Black Forest, and even evolving into a Warlord… You must have absorbed an enormous number of Magic Gems from the black wizard, right?"

"What are you talking about? He did not possess any Magic Gems."

"Huh?"

"Besides, the black wizard was the one who summoned me directly. Until recently, his commands were absolute. A summoned creature cannot defy its summoner."

"Then how…"

"You mean, how was I able to defeat him?"

The green light in the Skeleton Warlord's eyes narrowed.

"I do not know the reason myself. Not long ago, I suddenly felt that I had escaped his control. Perhaps you could say that I climbed one step higher when my magical power surpassed that of my summoner."

"Suddenly?"

"Yes. My magical power increased tremendously, all at once."

What was he talking about?

But just as the Warlord said, even he couldn't properly explain what had happened to him.

After thinking for a long time, he managed to add only one thing.

"Borrowing a human expression, it felt as if I had been possessed by a ghost."

"…Is that something a Skeleton can say?"

Maybe that bastard isn't actually a Skeleton.

It was at that moment, as I stared at the Warlord with an incredulous expression, that—

"Hmm?"

The Warlord's skull rolled around atop his neck, then stopped facing one direction.

The green light in his eyes shone as he gazed south and clacked his jaw.

"An intruder."

"An intruder?"

"I am master of the Black Forest. I know everything that happens within it. More wicked humans have just set foot in my territory."

"They're my friends, you idiot."

Whack!

I gave the back of his head a hearty smack, picked up the Warlord's skull, and headed toward the Gate entrance.

Chapter 299

“It looks like we can begin now.”

The Seoul Branch President finally gave the go-ahead more than ten minutes after the Peace Guild, led by Choi Minwoo, began protesting.

A Gate was a fierce battlefield where life and death could be decided in an instant. No one expected Jin Taekyung to survive after being left alone against a Named Monster commanding hundreds of Skeletons.

“Do you think he’s still alive?”

“It’s been exactly one hour and eight minutes. We’ll be lucky if we can recover his body.”

“Damn it. This isn’t a rescue operation. It’s a body-recovery operation.”

“Can they really do this? Every second matters, and they’re just dragging their feet.”

“What else can they do? This isn’t an ordinary A-rank Gate. A Named Monster appeared. If you look at it from the Association’s perspective, you can understand their position. If they rush in and cause a major disaster, it’s all over.”

Hunters preparing to enter and reporters filming the scene stood around talking in groups.

Some were furious about the delayed rescue operation. Others defended the Association’s decision.

But no one mentioned the possibility that Jin Taekyung had survived. There was no need to state the obvious.

“Still, the Peace Guild really got screwed.”

“Yeah. Jin Taekyung is already… Well, it’s unfortunate, but that’s how things turned out. And they openly raised hell with the Seoul Branch President in front of the cameras. The backlash is going to be brutal.”

“Exactly. That guy’s a political appointee, and he’s already ridiculously sensitive about the media.”

Choi Minwoo’s face hardened as he listened to the whispers around him.

Whatever repercussions the Peace Guild might suffer later?

He didn’t give a damn.

Who the hell says he’s dead?

He wanted to charge forward right then and there. He wanted to grab the idiots spouting that nonsense by the collar, then knock down the Association Hunters blocking his way.

The only reason he had waited this long was something Butler Kim had said while holding him back more than ten minutes earlier.

> “Didn’t you say so yourself, Young Master? That you trusted Mr. Jin Taekyung more than you trusted yourself?”

Those words had forced him to rein in his anger.

It was true. Taekyung had always shown them miracles. He had always made the impossible possible. Today was simply another extension of that.

Choi Minwoo believed it.

He wanted to believe it.

Isn’t that right, Mr. Jin Taekyung?

He drew a deep breath and stepped forward. Around fifty Peace Guild members followed him, their faces filled with resolve.

“The Peace Guild will take the lead.”

The Seoul Branch President gave him a hostile look.

“That falls under my authority as the commander of this operation. Yet from the way you’re speaking, that sounded more like a notification than a request.”

“That’s correct.”

“What?”

“Would you like me to repeat myself? I said it was a notification.”

Before the Association President could respond, Choi Minwoo continued in an icy voice.

“I have no intention of delaying any longer, and no reason to keep talking to you. The Peace Guild will take the lead.”

“How dare you—!”

The Association President’s face flushed red enough to burst.

That was when a flat voice came from behind him.

“Let them.”

The Association President turned his head.

Go Jun, Lee Jungryong’s right-hand man and Head of Security, stood with his arms folded and his face expressionless.

“Team Leader Seok?”

“Please consider the feelings of the Peace Guild members who have lost a comrade they shared so many hardships with. The media will look favorably on it as well.”

“B-but there’s a Named Monster inside the Gate. If we put untested Hunters at the front, something unfortunate could happen…”

The Association President fell silent beneath Go Jun’s cold gaze.

For a moment, he had forgotten. The man before him was no mere team leader in the Ares Guild. He was Lee Jungryong’s Head of Security and right-hand man.

He had also forgotten that the “unfortunate incident” he feared was precisely what Go Jun wanted.

The Association President deliberated only briefly.

“Let the Peace Guild take the lead. Then, three minutes later, the Association and the Ares Guild will…”

But Choi Minwoo had already turned and begun walking toward the Gate.

The gazes of the Association President, Go Jun, and countless others clung to him, but he paid them no attention.

“Let’s go. We’re going to save Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

At Choi Minwoo’s quiet words, a roar thundered across the grounds, loud enough to make their ears ring.

Butler Kim, Im Kkeokjeong, Song Song, and around fifty Peace Guild members followed Choi Minwoo, cutting through the hundreds of Hunters like a current as they advanced toward the Gate.

That was when Butler Kim’s resonant shout rang out.

“All Peace Guild members, form an attack formation!”

Clack-clack-clack!

Armor and blades flashed in the sunlight as they moved. In an instant, the Peace Guild members formed a wedge and shot forward like a single arrow.

At their head, Choi Minwoo charged toward the magic field with a thunderous cry.

“Enter!”

Swoooosh!

Never before had the Gate’s magic felt so unpleasant.

Choi Minwoo opened his eyes, a sense of foreboding stirring deep in his chest.

His heart sank.

This is…

Scorched earth.

Was there any better way to describe the sight before him?

From the hill where the Gate entrance stood, they had a clear view of the trail below.

It was completely engulfed in flames.

Mr. Jin Taekyung.

The foreboding he had felt while passing through the Gate seemed to be slowly taking shape.

Im Kkeokjeong spoke from behind him, his voice trembling.

“Team Leader Choi. What if Taekyung…”

“Stop. We’re in the middle of an operation. Don’t jump to conclusions.”

But this time, even Team Leader Choi’s words failed to reassure them.

The situation before them looked that hopeless. Im Kkeokjeong wasn’t the only one shaken. Every member of the Peace Guild was in turmoil.

No. It can't be.

Choi Minwoo bit down hard on his lip, steadying himself, then moved forward with heavy steps.

"We'll continue our approach. Stay alert and keep advancing."

They moved cautiously forward, prepared for monsters to appear at any moment.

But the closer they came to the trail, the deeper their despair grew.

"This can't be…"

A mountain of shattered bones and weapons. Ash blanketing the blackened ground.

There was no trace of life anywhere in that place, where death and destruction reigned. Nor was there any sign of the one person they had so desperately hoped to find.

Dead? Him?

The same question flashed through everyone's mind.

Those who had known Jin Taekyung the longest could only blink at the unbelievable sight.

Butler Kim's words broke the suffocating silence like a doctor delivering his final verdict.

"According to the results of the detection magic… we found no movement or living creatures within a three-hundred-meter radius."[1570]

Choi Minwoo's eyelids trembled.

"You mean…"

"I'm sorry."

His face devastated, Butler Kim extended a hand. Something rose into the air from the direction he indicated and slowly flew toward them.

"That's…"

"Judging by the considerable magic I can sense from it, it appears to be a trace left by the Named Monster."

A palm-sized metal fragment rested in Butler Kim's hand.

Its black sheen remained undiminished despite the ash covering it. Several people sucked in sharp breaths when they saw the chilling skull emblem.

"The skull emblem! Th-that's part of the armor the Named Monster was wearing!"

"That's right! We saw it clearly."

Then someone searching the area cried out.

"There's a dagger here too! It isn't the kind of equipment Skeletons use!"

"It belongs to Senior Jin Taekyung. It's the one he used all the time."

As shock settled over the group, Butler Kim spoke in a subdued voice.

[1570] Three hundred meters is about 980 ft.

“It appears he was oxidized along with every enemy, including the Named Monster…”

“…!”

The air around the trail seemed to crackle.

Now everything was certain. Jin Taekyung was dead. He had thrown away his own life, taking his enemies with him as companions on the road to the afterlife and leaving his comrades behind.

Im Kkeokjeong’s wail finally shattered the seemingly endless silence.

“Ghk. Nghh…”

A faint tremor began in his hands, climbed through his arms, shoulders, and back, then spread through his entire body. Tears poured from Im Kkeokjeong’s large eyes.

“Taekyung… Taekyung… Nghh!”

No one mocked him as his massive frame shook with sobs.

Their grief might differ in depth, but everyone there felt the same.

Grief over Jin Taekyung’s death. Guilt that they had been unable to fight alongside him. And the helplessness they felt toward themselves.

The Peace Guild members’ eyes grew red and bloodshot. Tears streamed down Butler Kim’s and Song Song’s cheeks.

Only one person did not cry.

Choi Minwoo.

He’s dead. Jin Taekyung is dead.

His dark eyes swept over the trail, where acrid smoke still curled into the air.

It felt as though Taekyung might be hiding somewhere even now, ready to spring out like a jack-in-the-box.

I thought you could survive anything.

His chest suddenly tightened.

He had not felt this way since losing his parents.

His grief swelled like a balloon, stretching taut, ready to burst at any moment.

Then a voice drifted over.

“My, what a gruesome sight.”

“Jin Taekyung is nowhere to be seen. It appears he really is dead.”

Choi Minwoo slowly turned around.

Hundreds of people had just entered the trail. At the head of the Association and the other Hunters participating in the rescue operation stood two men.

“It seems the rescue has failed. Wouldn’t you agree, Association President?”

“Indeed. Everything’s been reduced to ash. I wonder if we’ll even be able to find the body. More importantly, where is the Named Monster?”

“We’ll have to search thoroughly, but according to the detection magic, it appears all the problems you were concerned about have been resolved.”

At Go Jun’s words, the Association President’s heavily furrowed face broke into a broad smile.

“Oh, that’s welcome news. I thought we might have another casualty on our hands.”

“Your judgment allowed us to minimize our losses, Association President.”

“Nonsense. This was all thanks to the Ares Guild stepping forward. Once everything is settled, I’ll make absolutely certain that you receive a commendation plaque. Ha ha. It’ll be the first achievement of my term, so I’m thinking of holding a grand ceremony… Guild Master Lee Jungryong will attend, won’t he?”

“He’s not the Guild Master. He’s the Vice Guild Master.”

“Ah, of course. Goodness, I’ve become so forgetful with age.”

A dry smile touched the corner of Go Jun’s mouth.

“That happens. And if a commendation plaque is presented, the Vice Guild Master will be delighted to attend.”

“I’ll finally get to see him again. Please put in a good word for me, Team Leader Seok.”

“I’m sure he’ll be quite pleased if I simply report exactly what I’ve seen and heard.”

“Ha ha.”

The conversation between Go Jun and the Association President was a sharp needle—a needle capable of popping Choi Minwoo’s ballooning emotions.

“Shut your mouth.”

“…!”

Every sound died at once.

The Association President belatedly realized what he had heard, and his face twisted with rage. But Go Jun responded before he could.

“You’d do well to watch your mouth.”

“I told you to shut it.”

“Young man, you don’t know the meaning of manners. Don’t you agree, Team Leader Choi Minwoo of the Peace Guild?”

The words were barbed.

To Go Jun, Choi Minwoo was a kite with its string cut. The Ares Guild founded by his grandfather was already as good as Lee Jungryong’s. And now that Jin Taekyung, the troublesome figure they had been watching, was dead, there was no reason to hide his fangs any longer.

“I understand that you’re distraught over the death of a Guild member, but you need to calm down.”

Choi Minwoo ground out his reply.

"He could have survived if you bastards hadn't stalled."

"We did our best. The Association President's judgment was correct as well. And…"

Go Jun continued in a cold, dry voice.

"You people bear some responsibility too. Don't you agree?"

"…!"

"What were you doing while Jin Taekyung was dying? Leisurely reading the newspaper in your office? Or drinking at a bar in the middle of the day?"

Choi Minwoo bit his lip.

Everything Go Jun said was true.

Because he had trusted Jin Taekyung, he had set everything else aside and devoted himself to training.

But…

At least Choi Minwoo himself should not have done that.

Another needle flew at him as he struggled to speak.

"You killed Jin Taekyung. All of you did—you pathetic weaklings who forgot your duty."

"…!"

Go Jun let out a short laugh.

"It's too late for regrets. The dead don't come back."

Choi Minwoo clenched his fists until they felt ready to burst.

Then—

"What the fuck are you talking about, you motherfucking bastard?"

The voice was low but powerful, piercing every ear.

Those who did not recognize it stared around in confusion at the sudden profanity.

Those who did froze like statues.

No way…

Choi Minwoo slowly turned his head.

Far down the trail, someone was trudging toward them.

"You finished the whole forty-ninth-day memorial rite while I was off taking a piss, you fucking bastard."[1571]

Jin Taekyung hawked a wad of phlegm onto the ground.

"Square up, asshole."

[1571] *49jae* is a Korean Buddhist memorial observance culminating on the forty-ninth day after a person's death.

Chapter 300

The Black Wizard's Black Forest. No, now it would be more accurate to call it the Skeleton Warlord's Black Forest.

Either way, the gloomy forest was disgustingly vast and tangled. Without the Warlord surveying everything inside the Gate as clearly as the palm of his hand, I would have gotten lost along the way.

> • I knew you were wicked, but you are stupid as well. What would you have done without me?

"Right. Which way now?"

> • Turn right in one hundred paces.

"…How does this bastard even know the words 'turn right'?"

One captured Warlord was worth ten GPS units.

Swoooosh!

Following the Warlord's directions, I shot through the forest at dazzling speed.

Perhaps it was thanks to the half-jiazi[1572] of internal energy I had gained while performing True Qi Guidance on Team Leader Choi, but even as I used my movement technique with all my strength, my internal energy continued surging up like an inexhaustible spring.

More is always better.

After I had run for a while, the sounds of people moving and talking gradually drew closer.

My unbelievably enhanced eyesight picked out familiar faces beyond the brush, hundreds of meters[1573] away.

Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim. Uncle Kkeokjeong and Song Song too?

I could also see the new Guild members I had sent out about an hour earlier.

Forget those guys. Why were the people who should've been busting their asses circulating their qi all the way out here?

Then the facts I had forgotten flashed through my mind.

Oh. Right.

I had known there would be an uproar outside.

[1572] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; half a jiazi is thirty years.

[1573] One meter is about 3.28 ft, so hundreds of meters are hundreds to thousands of feet.

That was why I had planned to deal with the Warlord and the Skeleton army, then leave immediately. But the unexpected discovery of an EXP factory had gotten me so excited that I'd wandered away from the scene instead.

Things must have gone completely insane outside by now.

Then again, considering the supposed emergency, they had taken their sweet time getting here. At least an hour had passed since I sent the new Guild members out of the Gate.

I'll explain what happened. It'll be fine.

I was about to step out of the brush when someone shouted.

"The skull emblem! Y-yes, this is the armor the Named Monster was wearing!"

"We found a dagger too! This isn't equipment used by Skeletons!"

"It's the dagger Senior Jin Taekyung used!"

At the succession of shouts, Im Kkeokjeong burst into tears.

"Hk, nghh!"

"…?"

> • …?

"Taekyung. Taekyung… Nghh!"

No way. Was this what I thought it was?

As I stood there with my mouth hanging open, the Warlord rolled its green, glowing eyes toward me.

> • It appears those humans believe you are dead.

"Uh, yeah. There seems to be a huge misunderstanding."

> • Then should you not stop hiding like a rat and go out there?

But the situation was already spiraling out of control.

Song Song and Butler Kim suddenly began shedding tears, and even the Guild members lowered their heads with red-rimmed eyes.

The path grew heavy with grief and mourning.

"…"

No. I couldn't possibly walk out into this atmosphere.

What would happen if I showed up now and said, "Surprise! You thought I was dead, but I'm alive!"

What do you think? They'd curse me to hell and back.

The thought of dealing with the aftermath made me break into a cold sweat. Even so, I had to clear up the misunderstanding before the mood got any worse.

But first, there was someone I needed to deal with.

"You stay inside for a while."

> • Hmm? What do you mean?

"I don't know if this'll work… but people might be startled, so get inside for now."

> • Inside where?

Ignoring the Warlord's puzzled question, I immediately muttered the command in my mind.

Open Inventory. Store.

Pop.

At the same time as the command, the Warlord's skull vanished from my hand.

The Inventory was a space that living creatures could not enter. However, since the Skeleton Warlord was an undead monster that had lost its vitality long ago, it seemed to work.

"Oh, it worked."

> • Gah! Where am I?

"What the hell? You can talk from inside?"

Was it because the Inventory and I were connected?

I had never tried putting anything alive inside before, so this was a first.

As I marveled at the situation, the Warlord's shrill voice rang through my head.

> • What have you done to me? Release me this instant!

"Yeah. That's not happening."

> • Do you think you will escape unscathed after doing this to me?

"I think I'll live a long and healthy life, remain safe and sound, and never grow old or die."

> • It's so suffocating! I'm going insane in here!

“Why would you suffocate? You don’t breathe in the first place.”

> • You insolent wretch!

“Ah, you’re loud. Should I just make you disappear?”
The Warlord’s voice brightened at once.

> • This is a far more comfortable space than I expected.

“Good. Rest comfortably. And even if you do come out, don’t say a word in front of the people.”

> • Understood. But…

“But what?”

> • For a wicked human, you appear to have quite a few friends. Another considerable number of intruders have entered.

A moment later, I narrowed my eyes as hundreds of Hunters surged toward us like a cloud.
The Warlord was only half right. There were certainly a lot of them, but they weren’t my friends.
Especially the bastard leading the charge like a triumphant general.
Go Jun?
Why the hell was that bastard here?
The middle-aged man stuck to his side like his soulmate was someone I had seen several times on television and in the newspapers.
Even the Seoul Branch President came?
The Ares Guild and the Seoul Branch had both shown up.
This had become much bigger than I’d expected, which made it even harder to reveal myself.
I anxiously waited for the right moment. Then I overheard the two men talking and let out a hollow laugh.
“Would you look at these bastards.”
I had only caught fragments of their conversation, but it was enough to understand what was happening.

Lee Jungryong had sent Go Jun to eliminate the threat I posed, while the Association President wanted a connection to someone as powerful as Lee Jungryong.

Well, this was…

“Beautiful. Absolutely beautiful.”

One bastard wanted to delay the rescue operation to make sure I died, and the other had eagerly accepted his proposal. They were both pieces of shit from the same cesspool.

Even if it meant getting my hands dirty, I had to clean up this shit myself. It was hard to walk around without a care when turds like these were scattered across the road.

“It’s too late for regrets. The dead don’t come back.”

I saw Go Jun laugh quietly as he mocked Team Leader Choi. Without hesitation, I pushed through the brush and walked out.

“What the fuck are you talking about, you motherfucking bastard?”

At least one of them needed to be taught a lesson.

“…!”

Shock, disbelief, bewilderment.

With every step, gazes filled with different emotions flew toward me and struck me in the face.

As I passed, I patted the shoulders of Team Leader Choi and the Guild members, who had frozen at my appearance.

Greetings could wait. I needed to clean up that lump of shit before it stank any worse.

Step. Step. Tap.

My final step brought me to a stop in front of two men.

“You were… alive?”

“J-Jin Taekyung, Hunter?”

I gazed at the two pairs of trembling eyes belonging to Go Jun and the Seoul Branch President, then looked at Go Jun.

“Why? Disappointed I’m alive?”

“…Of course not.”

“That’s strange. Your answer came half a beat late.”

“You’re imagining things.”

Go Jun continued in a steadier voice.

“We were all searching for you. Where were you?”

"Oh, I went nearby to take a piss. But by the time I got back, you'd practically finished the funeral procession and even held the forty-ninth-day memorial rite."[1574]

"Urinate?"

"I drank a lot of water before entering the Gate."

"You certainly took your time."

"It's a symbol of virility. If you're interested, I can show you how to make a rainbow with my piss. It's really pretty."

"…Judging by the nonsense you're spouting, you seem perfectly fine."

"I'm always perfectly fine. But…"

I smiled faintly.

"Are you sick? The way nothing but dogshit keeps pouring out of your mouth makes me think you might have rabies."

"…!"

"I have to admit, listening to you was pretty entertaining. A commendation plaque this, a commendation plaque that—you were making a whole fucking production out of it."

Go Jun wasn't the only one whose face stiffened.

The Seoul Branch President, who had been silently swallowing as he listened to us, cut in with a flushed face.

"Young man, you have quite a filthy mouth."

"Yes, my mouth's a little filthy. But who are you?"

The Association President frowned at my curt response.

"You don't know me?"

"Are you the President?"

"No."

"Then you need to introduce yourself. How else would I know?"

"Good heavens. In all my years…"

Clicking his tongue, the Association President thrust out his chest, his arrogant face radiating authority.

His fat chest bulged beneath the suit jacket he had gone to the trouble of wearing into the Gate.

"I am Lee Woojoong."

"Oh, Lee Woojoong."

I scratched my chin with an innocent expression.

"Do you happen to know Kim Jeonghee?"

[1574] *49jae* is a Korean Buddhist memorial observance culminating on the forty-ninth day after a person's death.

"Kim Jeonghee? Do you mean the Association elder?"

"No. She's my mother."

"…Hmm?"

"Lady Kim Jeonghee. My mother."

The Association President was briefly lost for words. Then he asked incredulously,

"So what? What am I supposed to do about that?"

"That's what I wanted to ask you. Normally, people say what organization they're from, then give their position and name. If you leave all that out and just say 'Lee Woojoong,' what am I supposed to do with that? You might as well have said 'gynecomastia.'"[1575]

"What did you say?"

"So who exactly are you, Mr. Lee Woojoong?"

"I'm Lee Woojoong! The Seoul Branch President of the Hunter Association!"

"Ah. Nice to meet you."

"Y-you…!"

"Two twos are four. Two threes are six. Two nines are fuckin' eighteen."

"How dare you!"

I let out a short laugh as the Association President's face turned bright red, as though he might explode at any moment.

I knew perfectly well that the Seoul Branch President was one of the most important posts of all. Even so, I made no effort to hide my contempt because he was a human being who deserved to be despised.

A man who's supposed to be responsible for Hunters' safety and rights pulled something like this.

If anyone other than me had been left inside this Gate, they would have died.

The Association President had known that, yet he had delayed the rescue for an entire hour. All so he could curry favor with the Ares Guild—or rather, with Lee Jungryong.

"Jin Taekyung, what the hell kind of man are you?"

I stared coldly at the Association President as he shouted and pointed a finger at me.

"What kind of man am I? The kind who killed two Named Monsters alone while waiting an entire hour for a rescue team."

"Th-that…"

The Association President flinched at my aura and took a step backward.

But the distance between us didn't widen. I matched him step for step.

Step.

[1575] Taekyung twists the sound of Lee Woojoong's name into *yeoyujeung*, the Korean word for gynecomastia.

One step.

“President Lee Woojoong.”

“B-back away.”

Step.

Another step.

“If you’re the Association President, work for the Hunter Association. Don’t work for a Guild.”

“I-I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Would you like me to make it clear? In front of everyone?”

Step. Tap.

As I took the third and final step, a strong hand closed around my shoulder.

“That’s far enough.”

I grinned at Go Jun as he stepped between us.

“Get your hand off me. You smell like shit.”

“Do you enjoy escalating things?”

“Why? Are you scared?”

“Scared?”

Go Jun gave a dry laugh and whispered in my ear.

“You’re the ones who should be afraid. Everyone behind me is either an Ares Guild Hunter or an Association Hunter. If you want to get out of here alive, you’d better watch your mouth.”

“Oh, so if things go bad, you’ll bury everyone here and walk away? That’s a bit too big for you. Can you handle it?”

“That’s why I’m holding back. Consider yourself lucky.”

“Scary. By the way, are you all right after I beat the shit out of you last time? Drink a good potion?”

Go Jun’s eyes went flat.

“What a childish taunt.”

“Look in a mirror. Judging by your expression, it worked pretty damn well.”

“I’m telling you one last time. Back off.”

“And I’m telling you for the last last time. Take your hand off me.”

Huff.

Hot, foul breath spilled from his mouth.

Go Jun glared at me with sunken eyes, then took several steps back and muttered,

“If it hadn’t been for my Master’s special order… you would have died here.”

“Your Master? Oh, Jungryong?”

“…!”

“How’s Jungryong doing? Isn’t it about time you found him a place in a retirement community?”

That was the decisive blow.

Go Jun trembled from head to toe as though he had been electrocuted. His eyes flew wide, blazing with a light unlike anything I had seen when we fought at the hospital.

“If you think this will end the same way it did last time… I’ll make you regret it.”

“Regret?”

I beamed and spread my arms wide.

“You talk too much. Quit posturing and come at me.”

Whoooosh!

Chapter 301

Go Jun was utterly confident.

I can do this.

It had been some thirty years since he first met Lee Jungryong, after losing his parents in the Great Cataclysm and becoming an orphan.

“I’ve had my eye on you for some time. Would you like to come with me?”

“Me?”

“Yes. You have exceptional talent.”

Only then did Go Jun understand.

How a mere orphan like him had grown up with the finest education in the best possible environment. Who the anonymous benefactor he had never once seen truly was.

Lee Jungryong was no Daddy Long-Legs from a fairy tale, but that alone was reason enough to follow him.

“Yes, sir.”

“From now on, call me Master.”

That was how it all began.

He had to learn strange movements and unfamiliar ways of breathing alongside other children, but Go Jun loved every moment of it.

His tiny hands blistered, then formed calluses. The skin split, healed, and hardened… Go Jun’s life followed much the same path.

The pain made him stronger, until at last he came to stand at Lee Jungryong’s right hand.

“Starting today, you’re the Head of Security.”

“Please tell me what I should and shouldn’t do.”

“Follow my orders. Never defy them. That is all.”

His Master’s answer burned itself deep into Go Jun’s mind.

He lived his life by the path Lee Jungryong laid out for him—sometimes in the shadows, sometimes in the light…

He carried out countless tasks for Lee Jungryong, never once leaving room for error.

Unlike the Hunters who inflated their reputations and reveled in flashy lives, Go Jun concealed his true strength and quietly completed every assignment Lee Jungryong gave him.

Even within the Ares Guild, everyone could only speculate about his abilities. Lee Jungryong alone knew the true extent of his strength.

“Doesn’t it frustrate you?”

“What do you mean?”

“Always remaining by my side.”

“I’ve never thought about it.”

“With your abilities, you could make a name for yourself anywhere right now.”

“I have no interest in such things. I will always remain by your side, Master.”

“Ha ha. You seem even more dependable than usual today.”

Go Jun had meant every word. Every member of the security team had received Lee Jungryong’s teachings, but no other Disciple worshipped and revered him as blindly as Go Jun did.

Exceptional ability and unwavering loyalty.

Ironically, those two virtues were precisely what led Go Jun to defy Lee Jungryong’s orders.

“If it hadn’t been for my Master’s special order… you would have died here.”

“Your Master? Oh, Jungryong?”

“…!”

“How’s Jungryong doing? Isn’t it about time he started looking for a place in a retirement community?”

It was an insult Go Jun could not endure. To him, Lee Jungryong was a parent, a Master, and practically a god.

It was only natural for a fanatic to lose his mind when someone insulted the god he worshipped.

You filthy bastard… I’ll tear you apart.

The moment his Master’s order to avoid a clash with the Peace Guild was wiped clean from his mind, aura had already gathered around his fist.

“If you think this will end the same way it did last time… I’ll make you regret it.”

Go Jun already knew Jin Taekyung’s abilities from their brief clash at the hospital a week ago.

But that confrontation had taken place under his Master’s orders. At the time, Go Jun had displayed less than half his true strength.

Now Jin Taekyung would pay dearly for underestimating him.

I’ll go all out and finish this in a single blow.

He did not care about the aftermath. He only wanted to punish the bastard who had insulted his Master as brutally as possible.

And Go Jun had absolute confidence in his strength.

“Die!”

Whoooosh!

His fist shot forward like a ray of light, accompanied by a terrifying crack of displaced air.

Only three steps separated him from Jin Taekyung.

The bastard stood there smiling broadly, his arms spread wide. He was completely defenseless.

In a world that seemed to slow around him, Go Jun's fist drove forward with enough force to punch straight through Taekyung's chest.

Taekyung did not move an inch.

It's over, brat.

A triumphant smile had just begun to curl Go Jun's lips when—

Kkwaaang!

A thunderous boom split the sky.

But Go Jun never heard it. An overwhelming recoil surged through his fist as lava-like heat swept through his insides.

What is this…?

His vision flashed white. Agony engulfed him, as though a red-hot blade were churning through his stomach.

His mouth fell open, and something came pouring out.

"Bleeergh!"

Splaash.

Go Jun doubled over like a shrimp and vomited up his insides, his eyes bulging.

Blood.

There was blood everywhere. Unidentifiable pale objects lay scattered throughout the dark-red pool soaking the ground.

It did not take him long to realize they were pieces of his internal organs.

"W-what the hell…?"

As Go Jun stared in shock at the pool of his own blood, a foot suddenly entered his field of vision.

"Didn't you say you'd make me regret it?"

"…!"

"Strange. Doesn't look like much to me."

He did not need to raise his head to know.

He knew whose foot was planted in his blood. He knew who spoke with that ice-cold voice, blazing with barely contained heat.

How…? How did I lose in a single blow…?

One clash.

That single clash had become a pillar of fire, reducing the painstaking tower Go Jun had spent thirty years building to ashes.

How is this possible?

His entire body trembled.

Pain?

No.

What ruled him now was fear—an emotion he had felt from only one person in his entire life.

His Master, Lee Jungryong.

“Raise your head.”

That very fear seized Go Jun by the hair and slowly dragged his head upward.

A foot submerged in a pool of blood. A straight, steel-hard leg. A torso covered in the supple, powerful muscles of a wild beast.

And then…

A fierce light burned in his eyes.

Within the black forest, surrounded on all sides by faint darkness, two eyes filled with flame stared down at Go Jun.

“Give your Master a message.”

Hot breath brushed his ear. A whisper quiet enough for him alone to hear followed.

“As long as I’m here, no one lays a hand on the Peace Guild.”

“…!”

Go Jun’s eyelids quivered. A hoarse voice slipped between his blood-soaked lips.

“What… are you?”

“Me?”

A moment later, the answer echoed not in his ears, but directly inside his head.

—A descendant of the Fire King. I am the successor to the Blazing Flame.

The voice was like an auditory hallucination.

Go Jun did not realize it was Sound Transmission, nor did he understand the meaning behind the words.

Only one word filled his mind.

Monster…

The last thing Go Jun saw was Jin Taekyung’s playfully smiling face.

Then his body toppled like a rotten old tree.

Slump. Thud!

A suffocating silence descended.

No one dared to speak. No one could even move. Hundreds of trembling pairs of eyes swept over my entire body.

I stared absently at the unconscious Go Jun, then gave a brief assessment.

“So why the fuck did you have to start shit? You’re nothing special, asshole.”

“…!”

"…!"

The air froze in an instant.

When I looked away from Go Jun and turned my head, sharp gasps erupted all around me.

One person reacted more violently than the rest.

"Mr. President."

"Eek!"

Lee Woojoong, the Seoul Branch President, jumped and averted his eyes before answering.

"D-did you call me?"

"Why are you suddenly speaking so formally? You were talking pretty informally just a minute ago."

The President's face turned deathly pale as he stammered.

"M-me? I was?"

"Don't you remember?"

"Lately, lately my memory hasn't been so good. I keep forgetting things…"

"Oh, is that so? Then you must have already forgotten everything that happened between us today."

"…!"

"Judging by your expression, your memory seems just fine."

If he still could not take the hint after all that, he never would have risen to such a high-ranking position.

The President hurriedly shook his head.

"No. Of course not. I-I'll make sure everyone keeps their mouths shut."

"Keeps their mouths shut?"

"Gah! That's not what I meant."

"The people who came with you must have bad memories too. Right?"

"Y-yes. Yes, exactly. They all suffer from short-term amnesia. Isn't that right?"

More than two hundred Association Hunters had followed their direct superior into the Gate. Every one of them began nodding frantically.

"That's right."

"Of course. I don't even remember my own name."

"Wait. Where am I? Who am I?"

Who the hell said that last one?

I barely managed to suppress my urge to check his face.

"Well, that works out nicely."

I smiled broadly. The President and the other Hunters forced themselves to smile along with me.

Not that I expected this to keep everything quiet. There were far too many witnesses for that.

Next up…

"Who's in charge over there?"

"I am."

A sharp-eyed middle-aged man stepped forward. He was an A-rank Hunter and a team leader in the Ares Guild.

Still looking as though he could not believe his eyes, he glanced between me and the fallen Go Jun before biting his lip.

"I don't know what happened between you and Team Leader Seok… but you've made a serious mistake."

Judging by his words, he clearly did not know the exact circumstances behind the incident.

I grinned.

"These things happen. What can you do?"

"Aren't you worried about how the Vice Guild Master will react when he hears about this?"

"Not worried, no. I am looking forward to it, though. Be sure to report everything to Mr. Lee Jungryong."

The middle-aged man flinched, as did every Ares Guild member lined up behind him.

I could not tell whether it was because of the way I addressed Lee Jungryong or my shameless attitude.

Then again, I was far more interested in how Lee Jungryong would react to the report than in what any of them thought.

Looks like old Jungryong is in for one hell of a headache.

In this little production, Lee Jungryong had been cast as the cleanup man.

Since he would not want word getting out, he would have to cover people's eyes and ears, then switch off any loudspeakers that might spread the story.

It hasn't even been two weeks since that incident, and he's already showing his teeth again… Impressive. Truly.

We had barely finalized our deal, yet Lee Jungryong had bared his teeth again the instant an opportunity presented itself.

The thought sent a chill down my spine.

What if I really had died here?

That would have ended the fight then and there. Without me, the Peace Guild would never be able to stand against the giant that was Ares.

It also drove one fact home all over again.

If I let my guard down in this fight for even a moment, it's over.

There would be no truce in this war. Only an end. Our enemies would keep watching for the slightest opening to bare their teeth again.

"Whew."

In any case, I had done the bare minimum to settle matters.

Or so I thought.

"…"

"…"

"…"

"…"

Four pairs of eyes bored into me with terrifying intensity.

Dozens more demanded an explanation.

Ah. I forgot about our Guild.

I had forgotten the most important thing. But where was I supposed to begin? And how much was I supposed to tell them?

After a moment's thought, I opened my mouth.

"I went to take a piss."

"…"

Silence flowed through the area.

Then Song Song spoke in a gentler voice than I had ever heard from her before.

"Taekyung."

"Yeah?"

"Can I kill you?"

"…I'll explain once we're outside."

Right. Let's get out of here.

Chapter 302

More than thirty minutes had passed since the rescue team was deployed.

Hunters from other Guilds who had been assigned to guard the perimeter against any unforeseen incident had already drawn their weapons, while broadcast crews reported on the situation with microphones and cameras.

The commotion was not limited to the ground.

Dozens of combat helicopters circled overhead, and countless camera-equipped drones roamed the sky, broadcasting the entire scene across Korea.

“What are you watching so intently?”

“A live news broadcast.”

“News? You barely even watch variety shows. What got into you? Did something happen?”

“Do you carry your phone around as a decoration? It’s been over two hours since all hell broke loose over that Named Monster, asshole. Try checking the internet once in a while.”

“Holy shit. ‘Named Monster Appears… Jin Taekyung Presumed Dead.‘ Is this for real?”

“I don’t know. I can’t hear, so stop talking to me.”

At home, at school, at work, and even aboard crowded public transportation during rush hour, everyone was staring at a television or the phone in their hand.

The live stream on HunterTV’s iTube channel had passed one hundred thousand concurrent viewers long ago.

> └ Did Lord Fuck[1576] really die?
>
> └ Don’t say shit like that.
>
> └ I’m not trying to be pessimistic. Honestly, at this point, his chances of survival are slim. The golden window for a rescue operation is fifteen minutes, and there hasn’t been a word for over an hour. On top of that, they’re dealing with a Named Monster.
>
> └ Still, that rescue force was no joke. I’ve never seen so many A-rank Hunters gathered in one place.
>
> └ That’s my point—what are they rescuing? You don’t rescue a corpse. You recover it. No wonder the Peace Guild Team Leader was screaming that they were fucking bastards earlier. Safety matters, sure, but saving the person should come first.

[1576] An online nickname for Taekyung that arose from profanity he accidentally said during a broadcast.

> ㄴ Facts: Lord Fuck[1577] is already considered almost certainly dead. The deployed Hunters appear to be focused on raiding the Named Monster rather than rescuing him. Since there's been no word from the rescue team either, we can't rule out that the battle has already begun—or that they've been wiped out.
>
> ㄴ What? Wiped out? What happens if they get wiped out too?
>
> ㄴ What do you mean, what happens? The Named Monster goes on a foodie tour. It'll probably start by eating the people waiting outside as appetizers. The surrounding area is already under an emergency evacuation order.
>
> ㄴ Fuck, I've got such a thick layer of fat I wouldn't even taste good. Can't we just cook it some ramen instead? ;
>
> ㄴ Are you another fucking idiot? You think it'll go back into the Gate just because it's full?
>
> ㄴ Guys, for a Named Monster like that, what's its people max?
>
> ㄴ What the hell does "people max" mean?
>
> ㄴ The maximum number of people it can take.
>
> ㄴ Another idiot has joined the chat.
>
> ㄴ Do the assholes cracking jokes right now have nothing but udon noodles for brains? Have you thought about what'll happen if monsters come out instead of people the next time the Gate opens?

As one commenter had bluntly pointed out, the situation was more serious than it seemed.

The Hunters deployed there possessed overwhelming strength, but their opponent was a Named Monster.

If it possessed power beyond anything they could imagine, the result would be catastrophic.

There had been cases where a single powerful Named Monster caused tens of thousands of casualties and destroyed an entire city.

As time passed, tension began to spread through the chat as well.

> ㄴ There really hasn't been any news. Someone should've come out by now.
>
> ㄴ Aren't rescue operations normally like this?
>
> ㄴ Nope. Communication devices don't work inside Gates, so normally someone has to come out every thirty minutes and report that they're still alive.

[1577] An online nickname for Taekyung that arose from profanity he accidentally said during a broadcast.

> ㄴ Then why hasn't anyone come out? They said the battle site was just a stone's throw from the Gate.
>
> ㄴ Are they fighting the Named Monster? Shouldn't they deploy Central Plains forces?

Just then, the broadcast caught the Gate's magic field rippling like a wave.

At the same time, the chat that had been consumed by heated arguments began scrolling upward at a maddening speed.

> ㄴ They're coming out!!!
>
> ㄴ The magic field just moveddddd!
>
> ㄴ Go go go go go go go!
>
> ㄴ Please let it be people.
>
> ㄴ I want to see Lord Fuck[1578]. I hope he's alive.

On the internet, on television, and at the scene itself, countless people—roughly half the population of Korea—watched the change taking place at the Gate.

Then, in the next moment—

Whoooosh!

The swirling magic field of the Gate began vomiting out several objects.

Human arms and legs. Clad in gleaming armor and armed with weapons, they marched out in neat ranks.

They were not monsters, but the Hunters who had entered earlier.

"Wooooooah!"

The explosive cheer from the crowd startled the middle-aged man in a suit at the head of the group.

But he soon broke into a broad smile, his double chin folding as he waved.

"Yes! I've returned, everyone! We're all safe!"

> ㄴ I've been wondering for a while—who's that guy?
>
> ㄴ Lee Woojoong. It's written "Seoul Branch President," but you pronounce it "idiot." Everyone already knows he's incompetent.
>
> ㄴ Why is that asshole Lee Woojoong grandstanding?
>
> ㄴ The guy went in on a rescue operation and he's the only one wearing a suit, lmao.
>
> ㄴ Lee Woojoong, man boobs, whatever—quit blocking the screen and move.

[1578] An online nickname for Taekyung that arose from profanity he accidentally said during a broadcast.

Criticism flooded the chat.

The cameras mounted on the drones avoided Lee Woojoong and filmed the Hunters emerging behind him.

First came the government-affiliated Hunters from the Association, which had led the operation. Then the cameras captured the Ares Guild members walking out with grim expressions.

They were carrying a stretcher covered with a large sheet. As it swayed with each step, one blood-soaked hand slipped out from beneath the cloth.

Pop-pop-pop! Click, click!

Camera flashes burst from every direction. A wave of mourning spread through the people watching.

> └ Ah… I was hoping it wouldn't end like this.
>
> └ Jin Taekyung really did die.
>
> └ May he rest in peace.
>
> └ May he rest in peace. I hope he finds peace in heaven.

Just as everyone was swept up in grief, a voice rang out.

"Whoa. Why are there so many?"

"…!"

The news anchor solemnly reporting Jin Taekyung's death, the photographers hammering their shutters, and even the chat being flooded with messages wishing the deceased peace—

Everyone stopped what they were doing and stared wide-eyed at one person.

"Wow, look at all these cameras. By the way, is it really okay to broadcast something like this live?"

The young man looked around in fascination.

There was no one who did not know the name of the man wearing simple leather armor with a spear strapped to his back.

> └ …Isn't that Jin Taekyung?
>
> └ Huh?
>
> └ ?????
>
> └ Why is hyung[1579] coming out of there…?
>
> └ Am I the only one seeing a ghost?

[1579] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

As everyone floundered in a pit of confusion, one field reporter was the first to recover. He thrust a microphone toward Jin Taekyung.

“A-are you Jin Taekyung?”

“No, this is Patrick.”

“What?”

“I’m kidding. It’s me.”

This asshole was making jokes? On live television?

Reeling from the completely unexpected dumb joke, the reporter pulled himself together and asked another question.

“So you weren’t dead.”

“Seeing as I’m doing this interview here, it looks like I didn’t.”

“Then who was the person on the stretcher that came out earlier?”

“Oh, him.”

Jin Taekyung scratched his neck before answering.

“Well, how should I put it… He’s a Hunter who was injured while fighting bravely. His injuries aren’t that serious, so he’ll recover soon.”

“Then where is the Named Monster?”

“The Named Monster? There isn’t one.”

“What? Are you saying there was never a Named Monster in the first place?”

“No, there was.”

Jin Taekyung calmly added,

“Now there isn’t.”

It was the moment a legend was born.

“There’s something I’d like to ask…”

Team Leader Choi suddenly looked up from the newspaper covered in squiggly foreign writing.

“Why exactly are you in my office, Mr. Jin Taekyung?”

“Why? Am I not allowed to drop by?”

“I’m asking because you come here more often than I do, and I’m the owner.”

“Come on, these things happen. I only stopped in for a minute to see you.”

“The door was locked.”

“It was open.”

“You broke the lock.”

“Really? How strange.”

“I’m asking just in case—really, just in case…”

Team Leader Choi removed his glasses and asked calmly,

“Do you come here because of the seventeenth-century-style Russian imperial sofa made by the Russian furniture master Sorkovache?”

Sprawled across the sofa, I answered,

“Absolutely not.”

“Do you realize that saying that while lying there makes you rather unconvincing?”

“Nope. Ah, this is comfortable.”

The price tag was uncomfortable, but once I lay back on it, I could not tear myself away.

As befitted a chaebol[1580]—no, a third-generation hero—Team Leader Choi’s office was packed with things like this.

A state-of-the-art hologram TV with incredible picture quality was one of them.

“The next video we’d like to show you is the sensational clip that’s set the past week on fire. Johnson, have you seen it?”

On the screen, a Black man nodded in response to a question from a long-nosed white man. Looking at him, I could not help wondering why his name was Johnson.

“Of course, Conan. I’ve already memorized every line.”

“What line?”

“You know, the last thing he said.”

It was a popular American talk show, famous enough that even I had heard of it.

The co-host, Johnson, spoke with a solemn expression.

“It wath there. Now it’th gone.”

“Ha-ha! That was exactly the same!”

“…”

Exactly the same, my ass. Does he have actual snails in his ears instead of cochleae?

I shook my head and turned off the TV.

They were bound to play *that interview* again as stock footage, so turning it off now was the wise choice.

“Your popularity shows no sign of fading.”

“I know. I said it without thinking. I had no idea it would become this big.”

“I’m afraid I see it differently.”

Team Leader Choi had already whipped up a cup of coffee. He sat down across from me and continued.

“It wasn’t the words that became a hot topic. It was the man who said them. You hunted two Named Monsters, and you did it alone. Of course the entire world is paying attention.”

[1580] *Chaebol* refers to a large, family-controlled Korean business conglomerate or a member of its owning family.

A week had already passed, but the impact of that day had not faded. If anything, the flames were raging hotter than ever.

My official interview video on iTube passed two hundred million views within twenty-four hours, shattering the record previously held by an idol singer. Edited clips and all kinds of memes poured in from every corner of the world.

And on top of that…

"We've received another interview request from the American broadcaster CNM."

"Another one?"

"I already told you that BCC in the United Kingdom made an offer. They want to invite you as a special guest and said they can give you up to twenty minutes for a live interview."

"How special. Seriously."

Interview requests were pouring in from the flagship broadcasters of major countries anyone would recognize by name.

Of course, I had not accepted a single one. By now, merely hearing about them made my head throb.

"Are you still considering it?"

"Yes. If it'll help the Peace Guild grow, I should do everything I can, but…"

I lowered my voice until only Team Leader Choi could hear me.

"It's all a lie."

That was right. This was the most important part.

None of what surrounded me was actually true.

Team Leader Choi spoke with a tense expression.

"That… Did you bring it again today?"

"Of course."

With the solemn expression of a priest performing a ritual to summon a god, I chanted the incantation.

"Come forth, Warlordmon!"

Inventory. Summon.

At the command I uttered in my mind, a glossy black skull appeared on my palm, making a tremendous racket.

"Who are you calling Warlordmon?! I am the master of the Black Forest and the commander of the great Army of the Dead! I'm a Skeleton Warlord!"

"Warlordmon, forward roll!"

"You insane human!"

"Warlordmon, Quick Attack!"

Papapapapat!

Team Leader Choi watched me clutch the Warlord's skull and shake it at insane speed. Then he muttered as though he had attained enlightenment.

“Why on earth did you capture that thing and bring it back…?”

Chapter 303

A week earlier, the four people who heard my whole story had reacted in ways that were both alike and completely different.

“You captured a Named Monster alive, took control of it, and used it for raids? Hahaha! You crazy bastard!”

“…Are you actually fucking insane?”

“I’m sorry to ask this, but… have you truly lost your mind, Hunter Jin Taekyung?”

“You’ve gone insane. I’ll pretend I never heard any of this.”

Im Kkeokjeong was the only one who laughed. Song Song, Butler Kim, and Team Leader Choi looked at me as though I belonged in a psychiatric ward.

But what else could I have done? The moment the interview ended, the media erupted like an active volcano, and in less than an hour, I became a celebrity known to half the population of Korea.

“I should have stopped it then.”

Papapapapat!

Team Leader Choi lamented as he watched Warlordmon perform Quick Attack.[1581]

But the water had already been spilled, and for such a spectacular mess, it had been cleaned up remarkably well.

“Still, everything worked out.”

Even the government audit team, renowned for its thoroughness, failed to uncover the truth behind the incident.

That was only natural. No one could have imagined what had really happened. Besides, there was plenty of evidence to support the official story.

“The magical-power distribution survey conducted with a magical-power meter passed without issue, and they recovered both fragments of the Skeleton Warlord’s armor and pieces of its bones. It was an open-and-shut case.”

Everything left traces behind.

Unlike the other Skeletons, which had either melted or shattered under One Annihilation, the Warlord’s incredibly durable bones had retained their shape.

Still saturated with immense magical power, they were accepted as crucial evidence proving both the Named Monster’s existence and its defeat.

“Come to think of it, didn’t they put those soup bones up for auction? I wonder how much they sold for.”

“Soup bones?! Do not refer to my noble body in such a manner!”

“You still haven’t grasped your situation. Warlordmon, Body Slam.”

Thump! Thump! Thump!

[1581] Quick Attack is a move in the Pokémon games. Taekyung is addressing Warlordmon as though giving commands in a monster battle.

The Warlord bounced off the office walls like a tennis ball, clicking its jaw mournfully.

“Ah, my loyal soldiers. How I long to see you.”

“So, where’s this month’s tribute of troops?”

“…I shall replenish their numbers as soon as possible.”

Just then, the office door opened with a click.

A pair of shapely legs began to step inside, then stopped short. Looking up into a pair of light-brown eyes, I asked,

“What are you doing? Aren’t you coming in?”

“…Jin Taekyung, you crazy bastard. If you were me, would you want to walk into a room where someone was playing ball with a talking skeleton?”

“Yeah.”

I waved the Skeleton Warlord at the disgusted Song Song.

“Warlordmon, scare her.”

“Eeeeeeeek! Don’t! I said don’t!”

“Warlordmon, wag your tail.”

“I do not have a tail.”

“Then use Quick Attack.[1582]”

Papapapapat!

“Urrrgh, urrrghhhh!”

“Eeeeeeeek!”

Thank God for the sound-blocking spell.

Just as Song Song’s screams and the Skeleton Warlord’s howls blended into a perfect a cappella harmony, Team Leader Choi’s phone rang on the table.

“Everyone, please be quiet for a moment.”

Team Leader Choi stared intently at the screen. Several minutes passed before he finally spoke.

“I think I’ll need to step away.”

“Did something happen?”

Team Leader Choi shook his head at my question.

“I’ll tell you once this matter is confirmed. And, Miss Song.”

“Yes?”

“First, cancel the additional raid scheduled for next week. I expect to be neglecting my duties for the next several days, so please assist Butler Kim.”

[1582] Quick Attack is a move in the Pokémon games. Taekyung is addressing Warlordmon as though giving commands in a monster battle.

These days, even ten of Butler Kim would not have been enough. On top of handling the aftermath of the incident, he was leading the Guild members on raids and continuing his training in the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.

Of course, the five of us, myself included, were dividing the work between us. But as the Guild Master, he was busy on a completely different level.

"Got it. That's easy enough. It's not like we can make Uncle Kkeokjeong do it."

Song Song nodded readily, then paused and looked at me.

"But what are you going to do?"

"Me?"

"Who else would I be talking about?"

"Warlordmon, Quick—"

"If you do that one more time, I'll kill you. I mean it."

"…Attack."

That was probably enough.

I casually slipped Warlordmon into my Inventory as it spasmed reflexively like one of Pavlov's dogs.

"I'm getting ready to leave."

"Leave? I'm working overtime today."

"I have somewhere to be."

"Oh, really? What could possibly be so important that you get to leave on time while everyone else keeps working?"

I answered with a huge yawn.

"An exam."

"An exam? What exam?"

"What do you think? Don't you even know what day it is?"

Song Song blinked for a moment, then her eyes widened.

It was the middle of November. No matter how busy someone was, they knew what day it was. This was an exam important enough for the news to run a countdown to it.

"Are you taking the college entrance exam?"

"Are you crazy? My sister is."

I checked the clock on the office wall.

Five in the afternoon. If I left now, I should arrive around the time the exam ended.

"I'm heading out. Hang in there. You too, Song-i."

I rose from the soft sofa and left the office.

I could picture Mom praying fervently near the test center and Hayeon working her way through the questions.

I'm worried. She probably hasn't been able to study properly lately because of me.

For the past few months, the various incidents surrounding me had exposed Hayeon to the media and forced her to endure intense attention from everyone around her.

For a student on the verge of taking the college entrance exam, it was devastating.

I feel bad.

I could only hope her results reflected all the effort she had put in.

With anxiety gnawing at me, I headed for the test center. An hour later, I saw Hayeon's gloomy face and realized my fears had come true.

"You… Never mind. You worked hard."

"Yes, sweetheart. You've worked so hard."

At Mom's and my words, Hayeon gave us a faint smile.

"Well, look who actually showed up. I can barely remember the last time I saw your face."

"My little sister is taking the college entrance exam. Of course I had to come, you brat."

"Even after disguising yourself like that?"

"Is it that obvious?"

"Yeah. Sunglasses and a mask at night look terrible. They make you stand out even more."

"Damn it. No wonder people have been staring at me."

"Are you an idiot? Of course they're going to stare when you're so obviously disguised."

Her smile was gray and wilted, without a trace of energy. Seeing how completely drained she looked only made me feel guiltier.

"Are you okay?"

Hayeon answered with a miserable expression.

"No."

"I'm sorry. It's because of me."

"I thought I'd get a perfect score, but I got one question wrong in English."

"Here I am, your own brother, making things harder for you. I'm so ashamed I can't even look you in the face… What did you just say?"

"I got one wrong! I missed a perfect score on the college entrance exam by one question!"

Thud! Thud!

I stared blankly as Hayeon kicked the ground in frustration.

Is she insane?

She had missed only one question across every subject on the college entrance exam?

I knew she was smart, but I had no idea she was this smart.

No, more importantly, how does she already know she got one wrong?

Was that why she had come out thirty minutes late?

Either way, one thing was certain. This winter was going to be a fairly warm one for our family.

And…

"I got one wrong! One more correct answer and I would've had a perfect score, but I missed it!"

If I left that lunatic alone, the students and parents around us would cast a net over heaven and earth to hunt us down.

"Stop talking nonsense and let's go eat."

"Let go! What would someone with seventh-tier school grades[1583] know about how I feel?"

"Keep your voice down. Please."

I grabbed my hysterical sister by the back of the neck and dragged her away. From inside my Inventory, the Skeleton Warlord muttered,

"Blood truly cannot lie."

You're getting one hundred Quick Attacks.[1584] Guaranteed.

Time flew by.

With Hayeon's college entrance exam finally over, our family moved back into our old house once the remodeling was complete. Mom shed tears of joy at the unexpected gift.

"Son… Thank you so much. I don't know what to say."

"It's nothing. Please don't say that."

"I'm grateful too, son."

"Hayeon, now that the college entrance exam is over, would you like your life to be over too?"

Taking care of something that had been on my mind for so long left me feeling much lighter.

Even so, something still nagged at me.

They might go after my family.

Taking someone's family hostage was a simple but effective tactic.

I didn't think Lee Jungryong, who had a weakness, would resort to such a method, but I had to prepare for the worst.

[1583] Korean school-record grades use a nine-tier scale, with the first tier highest.

[1584] Quick Attack is a move in the Pokémon games. Taekyung is addressing Warlordmon as though giving commands in a monster battle.

I'll keep making money anyway. There's no reason to be stingy.

High-ranking Hunters earned so much that people called them walking small and midsize businesses.

But even those top Hunters couldn't compare to my income.

I cleared raids several times faster than other people, and I often fought solo.

For a Hunter, exceptional skill naturally led to wealth.

And if there was one more thing that came with it, it was fame.

"Butler Kim, could you handle the interview and advertising offers that have come in for me?"

"All of them?"

"No. Just the important ones that pay well."

Even though I accepted only a tiny fraction of the hundreds of offers, an enormous sum poured into my account.

That was how much interest people had in me, both in Korea and abroad.

A few advertisements, interviews, and appearances on television talk shows. That was more than enough.

The number in my bank account became morbidly obese, and the Peace Guild's stock price soared.

Two birds with one stone. A double windfall.

"May I ask you for one important favor?"

"Anything. Just say the word."

"Please find me a security company. A reliable one."

"Heh-heh. Leave it to me."

Mom and Hayeon never noticed a thing.

They did not know that the houses on either side of ours and across the street had secretly been purchased. Nor did they know that several seemingly happy married couples were actually undercover bodyguards.

They were only puzzled.

"Son, did you know a lot of married couples live around here?"

"Really?"

"Yes. I run into them whenever I go to the neighborhood market. Some are young and some are older, but none of them have children."

"It's the age of low birth rates."

"Oppa,[1585] only two men live next door. They walk around with their arms linked."

"…It's the age of gender equality."

That made them stand out way too much!

[1585] *Oppa* is a Korean term a girl or woman uses to address an older brother or an older man she is close to.

A few days after I asked the company to rearrange its personnel, I received a KakaoTalk[1586] message from Hayeon.

> **Jin Hayeon**
> └ **Jin Hayeon:** Wow
> └ **Jin Hayeon:** This time two women moved in
> └ **Jin Hayeon:** They walk around with their fingers interlaced all the time;;

"…"

Could this security company really be trusted?

Contrary to my concerns, the bodyguards did an excellent job.

Reports came in every thirty minutes, and they never took their eyes off my family.

I was so busy I barely had time to breathe, but everything was proceeding smoothly. Even so, there was one disappointment.

Leveling up.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You defeated a Lv.70 Skeleton Archer!
You gained an extremely small amount of EXP!
The difference in power is substantial. The amount of EXP gained is drastically reduced.

"Oh, shit. God, please!"

Despite my desperate pleas, the EXP factory was no longer much help to me.

Three or four level-ups. That was all I got out of it.

"Heh-heh. I do not understand this EXP or leveling up you speak of, but this is excellent news. Human, this is where greed leads!"

"But if I erase you, I can probably squeeze out one more level-up, right?"

"…I shall try harder. Please, anything but that!"

"Whew. I'll put that off for now. But you'll keep paying your tribute in troops."

"Why?! You just said you gain nothing from killing my soldiers anymore!"

"That's true for me. Our Guild members still need to gain experience."

"Experience?"

"We can use them to give our people some combat practice. Have your subordinates rehearse their acting. Tell them to make it convincing without letting

[1586] KakaoTalk is a messaging app widely used in Korea.

on that they're going easy on us. Of course, you know what happens if anyone on our side dies, right?"

"…You intend to suck the marrow from my bones. Just how cruel can the human race be?"

The Skeleton Warlord lamented, but I already held its leash.

The new Guild members gained experience in combat that was almost real against the Skeletons, who made excellent supporting actors.

That's right. Train hard and grow big and strong.

It was exactly one week after Hayeon's college entrance exam when Team Leader Choi reappeared.

"It's been a while, everyone. But before we catch up, there's something I need to show you."

With a tired voice and a stiff smile, he looked at us, pulled a USB drive from inside his jacket, and connected it to the hologram TV.

"This video came from China."

Beep.

The video began playing with a cold electronic tone.

Chapter 304

Every source of light in the office had been blocked out. As the holographic video began playing in the darkness, I suddenly felt as though I were standing at the scene myself.

This place is…

Everything was gray. I couldn't see an inch in front of me.

Only after an eagle's massive wing swept dangerously close did I realize where the footage had begun.

The sky.

The drone recording the scene descended rapidly, escaping the fine dust that filled the air.

Whoooosh.

After plunging through the fierce wind for some time, it finally emerged above a city engulfed in flames.

Boom! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

"Eeeeeek!"

"Aaaaaah!"

Factories belching smoke exploded one after another. Towering buildings toppled like dominoes, while people who looked like tiny dots screamed and fled in every direction.

Pandemonium.

There were too many of them to count.

Thousands were visible at a glance. Including those beyond the camera's view, there had to be tens of thousands.

"What the hell is this…?"

A groan escaped me before I could stop it. Was this because of some factory explosion?

No. It was because I had spotted creatures racing through the maze-like city, spreading destruction and slaughter wherever they went.

"Grrrrrrr!"

"Graaah!"

Massive bodies. Strength and Agility that could only belong to monsters.

Their eyes gleamed with killing intent as they swept across their surroundings. Then, letting out hideous roars, they began searching for targets.

Why are there monsters out there?

The question lasted only a moment before I realized the answer myself.

There was only one possibility.

A Monster Wave.

During the Great Cataclysm, Gates had been passageways connecting Earth to another world known as the Demon Realm.

But after the Demon King Asmodeus disappeared, the monsters' power weakened, and Gates became doors that only humans could freely pass through.

There was one exception.

If the mana inside a Gate exceeded its capacity, everything changed.

When a dam breaks, the water comes rushing out.

That was a Monster Wave, and the holographic video was showing us the result.

"Kyaaaaaa!"

"P-please, save me…!"

Crunch!

The camera zoomed in on the massacre unfolding in the heart of the city.

Monsters slaughtered and destroyed without restraint while humans died helplessly around them.

Some were impaled on monsters' claws. Others were trampled to death beneath the feet of the fleeing crowd.

Amid that maelstrom of chaos, a mother and daughter running for their lives caught my eye.

"Bingbing! Hold Mommy's hand tight!"

The woman had barely shouted the words when—

Whoosh! Thunk!

A spear flew from a dark alley, pierced her chest, and buried itself in the ground.

She vomited up a mouthful of blood, then her body went limp.

The child burst into tears at the sight of her mother dying before her eyes.

"Mommy!"

But it wasn't over yet. More than a hundred Orcs poured from the dark alley and advanced on the child.

They had taken up ideal positions to block the fleeing civilians' escape routes.

One Orc who appeared to be their leader raised an axe and brought it down toward the crying child.

Whish! Slice!

"Krk?"

The leader stared down at its arm in confusion.

The thick arm holding the axe had been cleanly severed below the elbow. Before the Orc stood a man who hadn't been there a moment ago.

"How dare mere monsters lay hands on the people of Zhonghua?"[1587]

[1587] *Zhonghua* is a Chinese term for China and its people, often used to express national identity.

A dazzling aura flashed.

Slice!

The leader's head was severed. Before it could even hit the ground, a thunderous cry burst from the man's mouth.

"Public Security Armed Forces Department!"

"Yes!"

The answer rang out.

The man was not alone. Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces, their armor emblazoned with China's Five-Starred Red Flag, were streaming onto the battlefield even now.

The man shouted, his eyes blazing.

"Kill every last one of those stinking bastards!"

"For the people!"

Sh-sh-sh-shk!

With a tremendous roar, more than a thousand Hunters charged forward.

Despite the enormous losses it had suffered during the Great Cataclysm, China still had a population of well over a billion.

The strength of each individual was unknown, but it would not be an exaggeration to say that China could mobilize more Hunters than any other country in the world.

"Wipe them all out!"

"Waaah! Long live the People's Republic of China!"

A thousand Hunters charged as one.

The monsters rampaging through the city weren't about to stand by and watch. Every kind of monster converged in one place, their numbers easily surpassing a thousand as well.

"Gwoooooo!"

"Kya-woo!"

Thud-thud-thud-thud-thud!

Monsters and humans. Humans and monsters.

Two waves that could never coexist surged toward each other.

Eyes shining with resolve, and killing intent directed at the enemy.

The force of the scene filled the office, so overwhelming that it was hard to believe we were watching a holographic video.

High above, the drone captured the two forces rapidly closing the distance between them.

Five hundred meters[1588]. Three hundred[1589]. One hundred[1590]…

[1588] Five hundred meters is about 1,640 ft.

[1589] Three hundred meters is about 980 ft.

Just as the deafening noise reached its peak and the two sides were about to collide—

“Perish in hellfire. Fire Rain.”

A cold voice utterly devoid of life.

At the same time, the gray sky split open.

Kiiiiing.

It was a sight unlike anything I had ever seen.

About thirty meters[1591] in the air, not far from the drone, the empty space peeled open as though something had sliced through it.

A massive ball of flame emerged from a vortex writhing with black energy.

Whoooosh!

The Chinese Hunters stopped in their tracks without realizing it and stared blankly at the sight.

“This can’t be.”

“This is… a dream.”

Unfortunately for them, it was all real.

Crack!

The sphere of flame, dozens of meters[1592] in diameter, split into four pieces. Each of those four divided into dozens more, and those dozens shattered into hundreds of fragments.

Then the rain of fire struck the earth.

Whoooom! KABOOM!

Rrrrrumble!

The deafening explosions dyed everything red.

The drone was thrown off balance by the aftershock. When it finally steadied itself, the being responsible for creating that spectacular scene was staring directly at it.

“A human device, I see.”

Its voice held neither inflection nor vitality.

The figure wore a robe covered in strange patterns, its hood pulled low. It extended one finger toward the drone.

I shall kill you all and take everything. Those who set foot upon my territory will pay with their lives.

Bzzzzzt!

The instant that finger, gnarled like the root of an ancient tree, moved, the video vanished in a burst of static.

[1590] One hundred meters is about 330 ft.

[1591] Thirty meters is about 98 ft.

[1592] Dozens of meters means tens of meters, or roughly 100 ft or more.

The gray sky choked with fine dust disappeared. So did the scene below, a sight that could only be called the end of the world.

With the hologram gone, a heavy silence descended over the office.

I was the first to speak.

“What the hell is that bastard?”

“He is the man responsible for this Monster Wave. No—he isn’t a man, so I suppose that isn’t quite the right word.”

Team Leader Choi continued in a subdued voice.

“A Named Monster. A Lich. That is what he is.”

A Lich.

A fallen archmage. An apex monster reigning at the top of the pyramid of countless undead.

The Lich that had supposedly vanished after the Great Cataclysm had appeared. It had caused an enormous catastrophe, as though celebrating its return after several decades.

Team Leader Choi unplugged the USB drive and spoke.

“November fifth. This footage was recorded exactly ten days ago by a reconnaissance drone belonging to Chinese intelligence. It shows a small city near Nanchong City in Sichuan Province. The estimated number of casualties so far is approximately three hundred thousand. An accurate count is still unavailable.”

Sichuan.

I was more familiar with it as the region where Qingcheng and Emei of the Nine Sects and One Gang were located, along with the Tang Clan, one of the Five Great Families.

Of course, Murim was an entirely different world that merely resembled China, and what the hologram had shown us was a catastrophe on an unimaginable scale.

“Three hundred thousand?”

“Yes.”

“That’s fucking insane…”

“And that figure covers only the first twenty-four hours after the Wave began.”

A chill ran down my spine.

Three hundred thousand estimated casualties in a single day. Had humanity suffered this much damage from a Monster Wave even once since the Great Cataclysm?

“Are Liches normally this powerful?”

I directed the question not at Team Leader Choi but at Butler Kim, the only one among us who had lived through the Great Cataclysm.

His eyes trembled like ripples on water.

“Of course not. The Liches I saw with my own eyes during the Great Cataclysm were all immensely powerful, but… that one is on an entirely different level. Its fire magic gave me goose bumps just watching it.”

Butler Kim was an A-rank mage who specialized in fire magic.

If a man who had been through hell and back during the Great Cataclysm said that, it showed just how powerful this Lich was.

Where the hell did something like that come from?

The burning city and the people collapsing in pools of blood lingered before my eyes. The enormous rain of fire that had hammered the earth was a disaster in the truest sense of the word.

I remembered the declaration the creature had made to the camera at the very end.

I shall kill you all and take everything. Those who set foot upon my territory will pay with their lives.

No one else could have understood what it said, but I could.

Thanks to the Integrated Language Pack, part of the System, I had heard every word clearly and understood what they meant.

That merciless undead monster would never be satisfied with a single small city.

Three hundred thousand people in one day? With the power it had displayed, the number of casualties might already be ten times higher by now.

“Goddamn it…”

I didn’t particularly like China, but no sane person could look at a catastrophe like this and laugh that they had gotten what they deserved.

The thought of all those people dying helplessly—and the little girl crying over her dead mother—left a bitter taste in my mouth.

Then something occurred to me.

Wait.

Now that I had recovered somewhat from the shock, one thing struck me as strange.

A catastrophe of this magnitude had happened ten days ago, yet the world remained peaceful.

And more importantly…

Where did Team Leader Choi get this information?

If it had been the Ares Guild—or Lee Jungryong—I could have understood. They were one of the world’s leading Guilds, and their intelligence network was exceptional.

But Team Leader Choi was just a team leader in an ordinary mid-sized Guild. If even he knew about this, news of the Sichuan disaster should already have been playing on broadcasts around the world.

There's something going on.

I wasn't the only one who had reached that conclusion.

Everyone was staring at Team Leader Choi, silently demanding an explanation.

He wasn't the kind of person who would fail to notice.

"One week ago, I received an unexpected message."

That was the day Hayeon finished her college entrance exam.

Team Leader Choi had spent a long time staring at his phone that day before leaving, saying that something important had come up.

"It was from China, wasn't it?"

Team Leader Choi nodded.

"Yes. More precisely, it was a request for one particular person to take part in this crisis."

"Forget everything else for a second. China specifically asked for me?"

"Yes. 'He' wanted you."

"Who's he?"

A name slipped from Team Leader Choi's lips.

"Xiao Yang."

"Gah!"

"Xiao Yang?"

"Young Master. Is that true?"

The moment they heard the name, everyone in the room stared wide-eyed. Naturally, I did the same.

I gaped at Team Leader Choi before finally managing to speak.

"X-Xiao Yang asked for me?"

"Yes."

"But who's Xiao Yang?"

"…"

Why did they all look like that? It was possible that I didn't know.

Team Leader Choi's eyelids twitched for a long moment before he finally spoke.

"Xiao Yang is the General Secretary of China's Central Committee."

"Jongseok?"[1593]

"The General Secretary! The Chairman—the Chairman of the country!"

Well, fuck me.

[1593] Taekyung mishears *chongseogi* ("general secretary") as the Korean given name Jongseok.

Chapter 305

“Are you feeling any better? You can’t have fully recovered yet.”

“…I’m fine.”

“If it gets too hard, take a rest. You may still be young, Team Leader Seok, but if you keep pushing yourself, you’ll wear yourself down.”

“I have no excuse.”

Lee Jungryong shot a glance at Go Jun, who answered with a pale face, and clicked his tongue inwardly.

I never expected him to go down so easily.

Go Jun was the most useful blade Lee Jungryong possessed.

Although his abilities were not known outside their circle, Lee believed that fewer than five people in all of Korea could stand against him.

Of course, two of those people were Cheon Taemin and Lee himself.

To take him down in a single move… He exceeded my expectations.

Lee could no longer deny it. He had underestimated Jin Taekyung and the Peace Guild.

The gap in strength was laughable, yet he was the one who kept getting humiliated.

His gaze settled on Go Jun’s bowed head.

“Go Jun.”

Go Jun looked up. Lee calling him by name meant this was a conversation between Master and Disciple, not between the Vice Guild Master and his Head of Security.

“Yes, Master.”

“You are the Disciple I poured my heart and soul into training. Never forget that.”

“I have never forgotten it for a single moment. You are more than a parent to me, Master.”

Lee Jungryong nodded at the unwaveringly loyal answer.

Go Jun fell short as a Disciple in many ways, but his loyalty was second to none.

Lee had held off until now in the faint hope that it would not be necessary…but the time had come to sharpen his blade further.

“You were not defeated. You merely fell. I will give you the strength to rise again.”

“Strength, you say?”

“For now, that is all you need to know. I will make you strong enough to defeat Jin Taekyung with your own hands.”

“…!”

Go Jun’s body trembled as he bowed deeply.

“Thank you, Master.”

"Always remember that your Master believes in you."

Despite his warm voice, Lee Jungryong's eyes had sunk to unfathomable depths.

Oblivious to that fact, Go Jun raised his flushed face. By then, the faint sound of someone approaching could be heard beyond the door.

"He's finally here."

Go Jun frowned at Lee Jungryong's mutter.

"He missed the agreed-upon time."

"Let it go. He's only in the first year of his term. He wants to enjoy it while he can, before he becomes a lame duck."

"Even so, to keep you waiting…"

"Team Leader Seok. Remember your position."

"Understood."

Go Jun returned from Lee Jungryong's Disciple to the Ares Guild's Head of Security and fell silent.

Not long afterward, the door opened and five or six people entered.

The middle-aged man leading them strode toward Lee Jungryong and extended his hand.

"I apologize for keeping you waiting. Traffic was particularly bad today. It reminded me once again how valuable an escort vehicle can be. Ha ha."

His manner was courteous yet confident. He was someone who could offer his hand first to Lee Jungryong, the de facto leader of the Ares Guild.

The middle-aged man wearing the Korean flag pin on his chest had every right to do so.

Lee Jungryong shook his hand with a faint smile.

"Think nothing of it. Thank you for making the trip, Mr. President."

Baek Hanseong, the twenty-seventh President of Korea and the youngest person ever elected to the office at the age of forty, nodded.

"It's been a while, Vice Guild Master Lee. Is this the first time we've met since my inauguration at the beginning of the year?"

"That's right. We seem to be meeting more often than I expected."

"Pardon me? Ha ha."

Baek Hanseong let out a dry laugh at Lee Jungryong's answer.

He knew full well how much power the man before him wielded.

People even said that Korea had two presidents and that the Ares Guild House was another Blue House.[1594]

He never once visited the Blue House during the previous president's term.

The major Guilds were impregnable fortresses built from power and wealth.

[1594] The Blue House was the traditional office and residence of South Korea's president.

And Lee Jungryong, the man who held the Ares Guild in the palm of his hand, enjoyed a status surpassing even that once held by the heads of the chaebol conglomerates.

There were two reasons Baek Hanseong could meet with such a man now, even unofficially.

First, he was still early in his term and enjoyed the full support of the people. Second, they had a matter in which they could help each other.

“They say people become more relaxed as they grow older. I suppose that doesn’t apply to me.”

“You really are refreshingly direct.”

Baek Hanseong understood the meaning behind Lee Jungryong’s subtle remark and held out a pristine white document envelope.

“An unofficial diplomatic letter from Chairman Xiao Yang.”

“Unofficial, as expected.”

“Yes. As you know, that’s how it is.”

The People’s Republic of China. As its formal name suggested, China remained a deeply rooted communist state.

The Communist Party leadership wanted neither unrest among the people nor any loss of faith in the Party.

“You’ve managed to conceal damage on that scale. I’m not sure whether to call that impressive.”

“If the truth comes out, all of China will descend into chaos. By then, there will be no going back.”

Among the tiny number of people who already knew the truth, however, the incident was being called the Sichuan Catastrophe.

The Chinese Communist Party leadership had announced that a major earthquake had struck and deployed the People’s Liberation Army to seal off the surrounding area.

“A Lich, was it? That Named Monster ended up helping China’s Central Committee, albeit unintentionally. I hear even satellites from the United States can’t see what’s happening inside.”

“It’s spatial distortion magic. Extremely powerful spatial distortion magic.”

“I see. I’m still completely ignorant when it comes to magic.”

“It may have helped the Central Committee, but it will have a negative effect on the war situation. We have no idea what is actually happening in there.”

Unlike his unhurried voice, Lee Jungryong’s eyes raced across the words on the documents.

A short while later, after confirming everything, a quiet mutter escaped between his lips.

"Thirty A-rank Hunters and two hundred B-rank Hunters…"

The documents from China were a contract to hire them as mercenaries and resolve the crisis.

They also contained one clause that Lee Jungryong could not overlook.

"They singled me out."

President Baek Hanseong nodded.

"They say the Central Military Commission strongly insisted on it. They believe the Ares Guild and your role, Vice Guild Master Lee, will be decisive in this matter."

"I imagine so. The situation must be growing desperate enough to spiral out of control."

"As you know, China has a great many Hunters, but relatively few of them are truly elite."

"That has always been China's problem."

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Lee Jungryong's fingers slowly tapped the documents. A calculator was whirring inside his head.

The forces China had requested amounted to twenty percent of the Ares Guild's total strength.

No. If Lee Jungryong joined them, that figure rose to fifty percent. Fewer than twenty S-rank Hunters existed in the entire world, and each one was an absolute powerhouse.

They must be desperate.

This was not the first offer China had made.

Three days earlier, Lee Jungryong had held a secret meeting with the Chinese ambassador to Korea. The footage shown alongside the proposal had far surpassed his expectations.

That was tremendous magic.

The ability to command more than several thousand monsters. Magic with overwhelming destructive power.

It was on an entirely different level from the Liches he had encountered during the Great Cataclysm. He had seen only a single spell, but that had been more than enough to grasp the danger this incident posed.

However…

Danger always comes with a commensurate reward.

Establishing a foothold in a dictatorship was never easy.

The Sichuan Catastrophe was a disaster to some, but an opportunity to others. And the terms China had offered were sweet—so sweet that Lee worried one of his competitors might seize them first.

As long as I'm there, this operation cannot fail.

Having reached his decision, Lee Jungryong finally spoke.

“I accept China’s proposal.”

“That is a wise decision.”

A smile appeared on President Baek Hanseong’s lips.

If the Ares Guild made a major contribution to resolving the crisis, it would yield considerable diplomatic benefits as well. As someone who wanted to achieve something significant during his term, Baek could not have been more pleased.

“I’m the one who should be grateful that I can help my country and Your Excellency. However…”

Baek Hanseong’s smile faded at Lee Jungryong’s next words.

“I heard a rumor that similar proposals were made not only to the Ares Guild, but also to several of the other ten largest Guilds in Korea.”

…

“I know it’s an unfounded rumor. But I thought I’d ask you, just in case.”

After a brief silence, Baek Hanseong answered.

“It seems a baseless rumor has leaked out. Nothing of the sort will happen.”

At that moment, the chief secretary standing behind Baek Hanseong thought to himself:

I’ll have to remove tomorrow’s unofficial meeting with the heads of Korea’s ten largest Guilds from the schedule.

Only after pruning away those irritating stray branches did Lee Jungryong smile brightly.

“Just as I thought. I understand. I’ll select the necessary personnel immediately.”

But Baek Hanseong was not finished.

“The rumor about the ten largest Guilds is false, but it isn’t entirely baseless.”

Lee Jungryong paused while gathering the documents.

“What do you mean?”

“Among the Guilds that received China’s proposal, there is one that does not belong to the ten largest Guilds.”

“Don’t tell me…”

A sudden thought flashed through Lee Jungryong’s mind.

At the same time, Baek Hanseong opened his lips.

“The Peace Guild, to which Hunter Jin Taekyung belongs.”

“…!”

Lee Jungryong’s face hardened.

Again. Once again, that bastard was getting in his way.

Those three syllables—Jin Taekyung—were beginning to irritate him even more than the name Choi Minwoo.

“That is rather inconvenient.”

Lee Jungryong’s voice rasped like sandpaper.

That green president, with a shelf life of only five years, had known about this and done nothing to stop it.

Lee was aware of the new president’s anti-Ares political leanings, but wasn’t this tantamount to openly making an enemy of him?

Suppressing the shout threatening to burst out of him, Lee Jungryong spoke.

“When there are too many boatmen, the ship ends up on a mountain.”

“I’m aware.”

“Your Excellency, this is not a matter that can be handled so simply…”

Baek Hanseong’s calm reply cut him off.

“The owner of the boat personally called for those boatmen. There was nothing I could do.”

“The owner of the boat… Surely not?”

“Yes. Chairman Xiao Yang named them personally. He specifically requested that Vice Guild Master Lee, the Ares Guild, and Hunter Jin Taekyung all participate.”

“…!”

Lee Jungryong’s eyelids trembled.

At the sight, President Baek Hanseong felt the same thrill he had experienced when he defied everyone’s expectations and won the presidential election.

Suppressing the smile threatening to escape, he glanced down at his watch.

“The Peace Guild is a very small operation, so perhaps that’s why they prepared so quickly. They should already be aboard their flight by now.”

—You treacherous human.

“Wow. So this is first class.”

—I was wrong to think you merely treacherous and foolish. I humbly apologize.

“Damn, these cushions are incredible. What kind of alcohol do they have?”

—You are mad. A lunatic. A mad bastard. A crazy fuck!

“Look how spacious these seats are. I could live here.”

—You insane human! Don’t go!

God, he’s noisy as hell.

Pretending not to hear the Skeleton Warlord screaming inside my Inventory, I asked Team Leader Choi, “How much does one of these cost?”

Team Leader Choi launched into his answer as if he had been waiting for me to ask.

“This new model from Focke-Wulf, the German aircraft manufacturer renowned for its outstanding technology—”

Here we go again.

I hurriedly cut him off before he could start explaining the history of Focke-Wulf’s founder.

“I don’t know if it’s Focke-Wulf or Pokémon Black Friday, but I’m asking how much a plane like this usually costs.”

“An aircraft like the one we’re on now should cost a little over one hundred billion won.[1595]”

“Hmm. I should buy one.”

Anyone who overheard me would have stared at me as if I were insane.

But it wasn’t impossible.

I recalled the conversation Team Leader Choi and I had shared only a few hours earlier.

“It’s a shame, but please tell Grandpa Jongseok[1596] I can’t go.”

“It isn’t Grandpa Jongseok. It’s Chairman Xiao Yang. In any case, that is unfortunate.”

I’m sorry too. Promoting my name and raising the Guild’s standing both sound good, but that place is a bit much.

They offered ten billion won.

How much?

Ten billion won. If you go beyond the promised period of one week, they’ll calculate an additional ten billion won per week.

Weekly pay? T-ten billion won a week?

It can’t be helped.

B-but I’m still not going. With thousands of monsters and a crazy skeleton mage, even I have to draw the line. It’s not like I’m some money-crazed bastard.

They say they’ll pay fifty trillion won to whoever kills the Lich.

Ah, now I suddenly feel like eating something spicy. I hear Sichuan cuisine is incredibly hot and savory…

…

Fuck it. Let’s go.

All the preparations were completed at lightning speed. Only Team Leader Choi and I would be leaving for China.

Chairman Xiao Yang had only wanted me in the first place anyway.

This isn’t about the money.

[1595] One hundred billion won is about $71 million or €65 million.

[1596] Taekyung’s “Jongseok” plays on *juseok*, the Korean title for a chairman.

I was going solely to help the suffering people of China and raise the Guild's standing.

With my face full of noble resolve, I turned to Team Leader Choi.

"But, Team Leader Choi."

"Yes?"

"If I make fifty trillion won[1597]… Do I split that with the Guild too?"

…

"Let's settle this before we go. Money matters need to be handled cleanly."

Team Leader Choi stared at me in disbelief before answering.

"We'll split it nine to one."

This guy was something else too.

As we stared at each other like we were both human garbage, an announcement came over the cabin speakers and the private jet sent by China began to take off.

[1597] Fifty trillion won is about $36 billion or €32 billion.

Chapter 306

As the enormous fuselage of the Boeing 747-8 VIP lifted into the sky, Jin Taekyung, who had been bouncing excitedly in his seat, sprang up and began roaming the cabin.

“Wow, this isn’t a plane. It’s practically a hotel suite! Team Leader, look over here. There’s even a bed!”

At his endless exclamations, Choi Minwoo pressed a hand to his forehead. Anyone watching would think they were going on an overseas vacation instead of heading to a battlefield.

“Um… Mr. Jin?”

“Hang on. I’m going to ask what kind of liquor they have.”

The private jet sent by China’s Central Committee had three Chinese flight attendants. Jin Taekyung called one of them over and began speaking to her in fluent Chinese.

No way. He’s practically a native speaker.

His command of the language was so natural that he could have been born and raised in China.

Choi Minwoo also had a talent for languages and spoke several fluently, but he was nowhere near Jin Taekyung’s level.

He had heard Taekyung was terrible at school. When on earth had he learned to speak Chinese that well?

Then a thought flashed through Choi Minwoo’s astonished mind.

Come to think of it, he talks to monsters too.

Jin Taekyung was, after all, the man who could speak the Demon Realm language—which even renowned linguists struggled to decipher—and curse fluently in it to boot.

When Choi Minwoo had asked how that was even possible, the only answer he received was that it was a trade secret.

…Let’s just stop thinking about it. That’ll be easier on my mind.

Giving up always made life easier. Besides, this was hardly the first time something like this had happened. Taekyung would tell him when the time came.

Resigning himself to that, Choi Minwoo accepted the glass the flight attendant poured for him.

“What is this? It’s clear, so I assume it’s some kind of vodka.”

“First Dew Fresh.”

“…”

[1598] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

"Heh. I didn't expect it, but they actually had soju[1598]. First Dew tastes best on the rocks."

Jin Taekyung dropped onto one of the cabin sofas and downed glass after glass. Appalled by the way he kept knocking them back, Choi Minwoo asked, "Are you possessed by the ghost of someone who died of thirst?"

"I'm drinking in advance. Going back and forth is a hassle."

"Excuse me?"

"Never mind. It's nothing."

After muttering that cryptic remark, Jin Taekyung asked, "You said it would take five or six hours, right?"

"That's how long it should take to reach Chengdu International Airport in Sichuan Province. It could take longer in an emergency."

"What kind of emergency?"

"What else could it be?"

The emergency Choi Minwoo meant was the Lich's monster army occupying Chengdu.

"Of course, that's highly unlikely. By now, enormous numbers of People's Liberation Army troops and Hunters should be defending the city."

One hundred million people lived across an area twice the size of the Korean Peninsula.

Chengdu was the administrative capital of Sichuan Province. If Chengdu fell, it would be as good as losing the entire province.

Jin Taekyung waved a hand after listening to Choi Minwoo.

"Come on. You can't rule something out just because it's unlikely. If we could do that, Monster Waves wouldn't happen in the first place."

"Of course, that's true, but…"

"Always assume the worst. Don't count on the best."

He tossed out the words casually. Anyone could have said them, but coming from Jin Taekyung, they somehow felt different.

How should Choi Minwoo put it? Beneath all that carelessness lay meticulous caution and the hard-earned instincts of a seasoned veteran.

He's a strange man.

There were times when Choi Minwoo found Jin Taekyung uncanny.

It wasn't a matter of skill or combat experience.

Whenever they talked, Choi Minwoo would suddenly get the feeling that Taekyung had survived far more than just one or two crises.

Even though he's younger than me.

Noticing Choi Minwoo's contemplative stare, Jin Taekyung paused with his glass halfway to his lips.

“What? Want some vodka instead?”

“No. First Dew is fine.”

“Right? It has such a clean taste…”

Jin Taekyung trailed off and scowled.

“This bastard’s throwing another fit.”

“…”

“I wasn’t talking to you, Team Leader. Some asshole won’t stop squawking.”

Choi Minwoo glanced at the flight attendants and lowered his voice.

“The Skeleton Warlord?”

“Yeah. He’s been raising hell about not wanting to go to China.”

“Because of the Lich.”

“Even if they’re both Named Monsters, they’re in completely different classes. And the Lich is a high-ranking undead monster, too.”

If the Lich was a big shot, the Skeleton Warlord was a nobody. Becoming a Named Monster did not change the vast difference in their origins.

Besides, the Lich that had appeared this time was powerful enough to stand apart even from those seen during the Great Cataclysm.

Choi Minwoo’s expression grew serious.

“Mr. Jin.”

“Ah, shut up already! Sorry, what?”

“Something has been going wrong lately.”

“Did you throw out your back?”

“No. I mean the way things are going in the world.”

“Oh, the atmosphere. Same here. I want to live peacefully, but all these pieces of shit keep raising hell from every direction… Ah, I wasn’t talking about you, so shut up.”

A headache struck Choi Minwoo without warning. He rubbed the space between his brows.

“I’m talking about Gates and monsters.”

“Oh.”

Jin Taekyung looked up from his argument with the invisible Skeleton Warlord.

“It is strange. Normally, we might see one Named Monster every few years, but two of them have shown up in the span of a few months.”

“Gate accidents have also risen sharply this year. The media, always eager to tear someone apart, are blaming careless Guilds and individuals. But I’m not convinced. The International Gate Research Institute has reached the exact opposite conclusion.”

Choi Minwoo handed him a tablet. Across its screen, in large, bold letters, were the words **Investigation Results: Sudden Increase in Gate Mana**.

“They haven’t made an official announcement, but the matter is already considered settled. Mana density has been rising rapidly inside a considerable number of Gates.”

“That’s the real cause of the recent spate of Gate accidents?”

“Yes.”

Mana was the source of a monster’s power. If the mana density inside a Gate increased, the monsters within it would naturally grow stronger.

And above all…

“I’ve got the proof right here.”

At Jin Taekyung’s words, Choi Minwoo nodded.

The Skeleton Warlord. According to what Taekyung had told him a few days earlier, the Named Monster had *evolved*.

The change had been so sudden that even the Warlord himself did not know why it had happened.

“The Lich that appeared this time may have experienced the same growth in power.”

“I expected something like that to some extent. But…”

Jin Taekyung swept back his long hair.

“This is going to be fucking brutal.”

“That’s why we need adequate countermeasures. According to some of the information I obtained regarding this incident…”

“I’ll look at it later.”

“Excuse me?”

“I’ve got a lot to catch up on right now.”

“Catch up on? Right now?”

The Boeing 747-8 VIP was cruising at an altitude of twenty-five thousand feet.

What overdue business could he possibly deal with up here?

Jin Taekyung’s answer only left Choi Minwoo more baffled.

“I’m going to sleep.”

“Sleep? At a time like this?”

“I haven’t been able to sleep at all lately.”

“W-wait a moment.”

“Don’t wake me under any circumstances. This is the answer for now.”

What kind of person was this?

Before Choi Minwoo could stop him, Jin Taekyung crawled into the bed inside the cabin. Choi Minwoo could only gape.

“Oh, right. Team Leader Choi.”

Jin Taekyung poked his head back out, his expression grave.

“Please turn off the lights.”

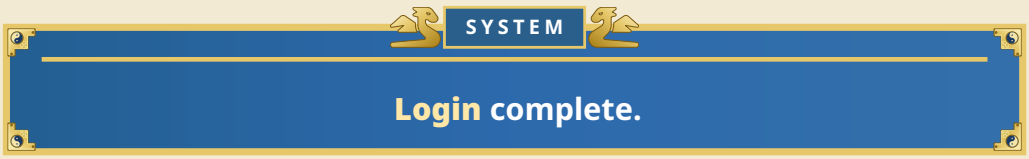
“…”

The moment his head touched the pillow, Jin Taekyung fell peacefully asleep.

Watching him, Choi Minwoo thought:

The profit split is nine to one. No exceptions.

Ding.



I opened my eyes to the hardness of a wooden pillow and bed instead of a soft pillow and mattress.

Above me was the wholly unfamiliar ceiling of a Murim Alliance pavilion.

I’m back.

A full month had passed since I left. In the Murim, not even two shichen[1599] would have passed.

I turned my head to the right and saw a small old man fast asleep.

Even with sunlight streaming through the window and shining directly on his face, he—the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang—did not stir.

“I’m back, Old Master.”

I had just murmured the words and started to rise when—

“Oh. Mm. Ah.”

“…”

“There. That’s good. Yeah.”

I stared down at Hyuk Mujin, who was writhing like a worm in the corner of the room.

I’m pretty sure I left him on guard duty before logging out.

I told this lunatic to stand guard, and he was having a wet dream.

My greatest regret in life was that I couldn’t record this and share it in the Jin Family of Taiyuan group chat.

I could still kick him in the ass, though.

Bam!

“Urgh!”

[1599] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours. Two shichen are about four hours.

"Wake up, you Tokyo Hot[1600] bastard."

The pain jolted Hyuk Mujin out of his blissful dream, and he sprang to his feet.

"Captain, you're awake!"

"Yeah. Looks like you just got up too."

Hyuk Mujin's eyes darted around as an awkward smile crept across his face.

"Ah, well. Something came up."

"…"

Did something come up, or were you about to come?

I glared at Hyuk Mujin in disgust and let out a deep sigh.

Fine. This was all my fault for trusting him.

"Whew. How long were you asleep?"

"Not long. I swear."

"Then nothing unusual happened while you were awake?"

"Yes. Until two shichen[1601] ago, I kept watch so thoroughly that I wouldn't have let even a single ant get inside."

I thought about that for a moment.

"If it was two shichen[1602] ago, wasn't that when I had just fallen asleep?"

"Well, now that you mention it… But I really wasn't asleep for long."

"Right. Two shichen[1603] isn't long."

"Yes, yes."

"Our Mujin followed me into my dreams to protect me, huh?"

Hyuk Mujin nodded furiously.

"That's right! I, Hyuk Mujin, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, pledge my unwavering loyalty to you, Captain!"

"My, what a good boy."

I chuckled and picked up the flower vase beside the bed.

"Then why did you make such strange moaning sounds while guarding me in my dream?"

"Gasp."

"Who did you meet? Mimi from Honghwaru[1604]? Kirara from Tokyo-ru[1605]? Or the filial daughter from the soft tofu restaurant?"

[1600] Tokyo Hot is a Japanese adult-video studio.

[1601] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours. Two shichen are about four hours.

[1602] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours. Two shichen are about four hours.

[1603] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours. Two shichen are about four hours.

[1604] Honghwaru is a pleasure house in Taiyuan.

[1605] Tokyo-ru is a red-light establishment invoked in Taekyung's joke.

I'd had it. Just looking at that bastard made rage burn in my chest until I could barely breathe.

I raised the flower vase high, and Hyuk Mujin cautiously backed away.

"P-please let me off just this once."

"I've let you off five hundred times already."

"Then since you've let me off five hundred times, just one more time…"

"Hold still."

Whoosh!

At that moment, three things happened simultaneously.

First, the flower vase in my hand shot forward with tremendous force.

Second, it narrowly grazed the crown of Hyuk Mujin's bowed head and flew toward the door.

Third, with impossibly perfect timing, the door opened and someone walked in.

"How is Great Hero Jeok's condi—"

Bam!

The squat old man carrying a small cloth-wrapped bundle could not finish his sentence.

His eyes went slack as he stared at Hyuk Mujin and me. His lips moved several times before he slowly crumpled.

Thud. Crash!

The flower vase that had struck him squarely in the forehead rolled away, while acupuncture needles and all manner of medical instruments spilled from his bundle.

"…"

"…"

The Luoyang Strange Physician had come at first light to check on Jeok Cheongang's condition.

And that was how he collapsed with a concussion.

Chapter 307

“The world looks new.”

Those were the first words out of the Luoyang Strange Physician’s mouth when he regained consciousness one shichen[1606] later.

His tone and voice were so gentle that I could hardly believe he was the same old man who had been flying into a rage before I returned to the modern world.

“A-are you all right?”

“Of course I’m all right. My head hurts a little, but these things happen.”

I was starting to get scared.

How eccentric did someone have to be for people to call him the Strange Physician to his face?

Yet one flower vase to the head had transformed him into a completely different person.

Even the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, who had rushed over after mistaking the commotion for an attack by Dark Heaven, asked him anxiously, “Strange Physician, are you sure you’re all right?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician smiled faintly and nodded.

“Ha-ha, Great Hero Mae. You need not worry about this old man. Just take special care to ensure that this promising young man isn’t injured in the coming war.”

“You…!”

“Elder…!”

This was the greatest physician in Henan. A true doctor!

And I had actually grumbled to Mae Jonghak that such a good man was a quack.

Overcome with emotion and shame, I bowed my head. Then the Luoyang Strange Physician’s voice reached my ears.

“Because if that young man were gravely injured and I had to treat him, I might just drive a large acupuncture needle into one of his lethal acupoints with this very hand. Ha-ha.”

“…”

“…”

“A physician cannot commit murder, can he?”

So that was what he meant by making sure I didn’t get hurt.

A chill ran down my spine as I raised my head. The Luoyang Strange Physician met my gaze and smiled like the kindly old man next door.

“Great Hero Jeok’s Disciple or not, I ought to gouge those eyes right out. Ha-ha.”

“…”

[1606] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Forget the old man next door. He was more like the murderer next door.

Still wearing a bandage wound tightly around his head and laughing like a lunatic, the Luoyang Strange Physician began the examination of Jeok Cheongang that he had put off for a while.

Whatever his personality, he was the greatest physician in Henan and a medical master counted among the ten best in the world.

But after examining Jeok Cheongang for a little over an hour, he reached much the same conclusion as before.

“I don’t know. This is truly strange.”

“There’s… no way to treat him?”

“You’re asking whether there’s no way to treat him?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician gave me a displeased look before continuing.

“There is no incurable illness under heaven. But how can I find a treatment when I don’t even know the name of the disease?”

This was hopeless.

If we at least knew what the illness was, we might be able to find a treatment somehow. But this meant it was an unknown disease.

I took Jeok Cheongang’s wrinkled hand in mine.

Why can’t someone as strong as you wake up?

Was it because he couldn’t bear the shock of losing his closest friend after already losing his Disciple?

No. The Jeok Cheongang I knew was far more steadfast than that.

Then…

The aftereffects of the Dance of the Fire God and Demon? Or did that bastard Blood Lord pull some kind of trick?

The Dance of the Fire God and Demon was a double-edged sword that consumed even its user’s life. Its power must have been more than the aged Jeok Cheongang could bear.

And the Blood Lord, one of Dark Heaven’s core figures, was exactly the kind of bastard who would resort to some dirty trick.

The Luoyang Strange Physician groaned under his breath.

“No demonic qi has seeped into him, and he hasn’t been poisoned. But if this continues, his qi channels will slowly become blocked. That much is certain.”

Mae Jonghak’s eyes and mine flew open at the same time.

“What? What does that…?”

“Strange Physician, didn’t you say his life wasn’t in danger?”

“You weren’t listening properly. I clearly said his life was not in danger *for now*.”

The Luoyang Strange Physician continued slowly.

“I could tell from his pulse today that he is different from yesterday. If Great Hero Jeok remains in this state and does not wake up, all his qi acupoints will become blocked, and he will be reduced to an ordinary countryman.”

“Are you saying he won’t regain consciousness until after he loses his martial arts?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician shook his head.

“I cannot guarantee even that. And even if Heaven helps Great Hero Jeok awaken, his body has already outlived its natural span. How much longer could it possibly endure?”

“…!”

I felt as though someone had struck me in the back of the head with a hammer.

As the Luoyang Strange Physician said, Jeok Cheongang had already lived for more than a hundred years.

The Fire King might endure for another ten or twenty years, but only because he possessed tremendous internal energy and martial arts.

How much time would remain for Jeok Cheongang the old man, rather than Jeok Cheongang the Fire King?

“Six months. If we continue guiding his qi through his acupoints, we might buy him another couple of months, but no more.”

“Six months… Is there really no other way?”

“You insolent brat. Do you need to make this old man repeat himself twice before you’ll be satisfied?”

He didn’t know what the disease was, so he didn’t know how to cure it.

The Luoyang Strange Physician’s answer was so firm that it doused the tiny spark of hope.

But he was also the one who rekindled it.

“That is why you must find the Divine Physician.”

“The Divine Physician?”

My mind snapped fully awake, as if someone had dumped a bucket of ice water over my head. I opened my eyes wide and asked:

“Who is the Divine Physician?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician stared at me in surprise.

“…You don’t know the Divine Physician?”

“He sounds like a physician. A really skilled one.”

“His sobriquet is Divine Physician, so of course he is! Even a stray dog in a back alley would know that much. Great Hero Mae, is this fellow really a martial artist?”

Mae Jonghak, who had been standing a step away, stopped the enraged Luoyang Strange Physician.

“Calm down, Strange Physician.”

“There are limits to ignorance, even for a complete outsider. How can he not know the Divine Physician?”

“Hmm. He must be famous.”

“…What?”

“…Huh?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician and I whipped our heads around at the same time. Mae Jonghak was smiling innocently.

Where have I seen that smile before?

Oh, right.

Wearing a smile exactly like Cheongpung’s, Mae Jonghak said, “I’ve been secluded deep in the mountains for nearly thirty years, you see. Ha-ha.”

“What are you talking about? It has already been more than forty years since the Divine Physician made his name known throughout the martial world.”

Mae Jonghak fell silent for a moment after the Luoyang Strange Physician’s blunt correction. Then he replied, “Come to think of it, it has been more than forty years for this old man as well. It was so long ago that I got confused.”

“…”

“…”

That was dark, Chuseong.[1607]

The Divine Physician.

Just as his sobriquet suggested, his medical skills had reached the realm of the divine.

It was said that he had appeared at the edge of the continent more than forty years ago and performed feats of medicine bordering on the miraculous. After treating thousands of patients by himself and stamping out an epidemic, he earned the sobriquet Divine Physician.

“Afterward, the Divine Physician continued to share his medical skills freely. He never turned away a patient who came to him and never accepted any payment. He was a true physician whose character was as lofty as his medical ability.”

“Ooh, a god-tier doctor.”

“The powerful figures of the world tried to retain him as an honored guest, but every time, he vanished without a trace. He would say only that he intended to care for patients in the lowest places.”

[1607] The Korean line swaps syllables in an insult meaning “Pathetic, Sword Saint,” mangling the Sword Saint’s title.

“Ooh, the Medicine Immortal Hong Gil-dong.[1608]”

“He always covered his face with a white veil, so no one ever saw what he looked like, but…”

“Ooh, the masked physician.”

The Luoyang Strange Physician, who had been about to continue, picked up a large acupuncture needle a handspan long.

“I’ll shut that mouth of yours for you.”

“I’m sorry. It just slipped out.”

“Even with Great Hero Mae here, this young brat’s mouth never stops. Isn’t that right?”

Mae Jonghak’s eyes lit up.

“Ooh, the Divine Physician.”

“…”

After that, the Luoyang Strange Physician, now half a sage, gave us a kind but concise explanation of the Divine Physician.

He was universally recognized as the greatest physician under heaven and a man of noble character.

And…

“No one knows his identity?”

“Did I not tell you that he always wears a veil while practicing medicine?”

“Even so, he’s been active for over forty years. How can no one know what he looks like?”

Seriously, one good gust of wind should have been enough to expose his face.

But the Luoyang Strange Physician shook his head.

“Someone may know. But no one in the world has ever properly identified him.”

“Why? Because he always ran away before anyone could track him down?”

“The witnesses contradicted one another every time. Some commoners said the Medicine Immortal was an old man with white hair, while others claimed he was a shaven-headed Buddhist nun. No matter how people tracked down and cajoled those who had seen the Medicine Immortal, their accounts never matched. How could anyone possibly find him?”

“Huh.”

“His reputation among the common people is absolute. So many of them willingly served as his eyes and ears and helped conceal his identity that even the imperial palace eventually gave up searching for him.”

“I understand that this Divine Physician is impressive, but…”

I stared incredulously at the Luoyang Strange Physician’s pleased smile.

[1608] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw known for helping the oppressed and vanishing from those who pursued him.

“How am I supposed to find someone even the imperial palace gave up on?”

“Oh. Good point.”

“…”

Was he joking right now?

When my expression darkened, the Luoyang Strange Physician suddenly burst into hearty laughter.

“Don’t worry. Would I have brought him up if I had no plan at all?”

“Just as I thought. I knew I could trust you, Elder.”

“Ten years ago, I heard the tales of the Divine Physician and was so deeply impressed that I set out on a medical tour.”

“Oh, a medical tour.”

I had heard about such things in passing when I was still holed up with the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Just as martial artists went on dueling tours, physicians went on medical tours.

The Luoyang Strange Physician had followed the trail of the Divine Physician’s deeds, crossing the continent from its most remote reaches over the course of five years.

“It was rewarding and brought me great joy. But for a man already past sixty, it was also an arduous journey.”

Still, he had found something at the end of it.

“Something I had only imagined came to pass.”

The unexpected gift had come to him in a slash-and-burn farming village in the southern part of the continent.

The slash-and-burn farmers, who barely had enough to eat and had received no education, told him about a benefactor who had treated their illnesses and departed only a few months earlier.

“You folks have nothing that needs treatment. I’ll leave a few silver coins behind, so use them to restore your strength.”

“Um…”

“What is it? I’m sorry, but this is all the money I have left…”

“That isn’t it. Are you perhaps a physician from Luoyang?”

“Why do you ask?”

“The benefactor who treated us not long ago said that if a physician surnamed Oh came from Luoyang, we should give him this.”

What they handed him was a jade-colored shard from a porcelain bottle.

That shard now rested in the Luoyang Strange Physician’s hand.

“What is this…?”

“Read what’s written on it.”

Faint writing remained on the shard in his wrinkled palm.

Chinese gallnuts from Sichuan are the finest.

What the hell did that mean?

As I stared at it in confusion, the Luoyang Strange Physician explained, “Chinese gallnut is a widely used medicinal ingredient. With this one line, the Divine Physician was subtly telling me that he was in Sichuan.”

“…That’s what you got from it?”

“I’m telling you, that’s what it means.”

“Then if I say Japanese adult videos are the best, does that mean I’m in Japan?”

“What kind of insane nonsense is that? Great Hero Mae, isn’t this fellow completely mad?”

Looking ready to die of curiosity, Mae Jonghak asked, “What in the world are these ‘adult videos’?”

“That’s not important right now!”

The Luoyang Strange Physician, hopping mad, placed the shard in my palm.

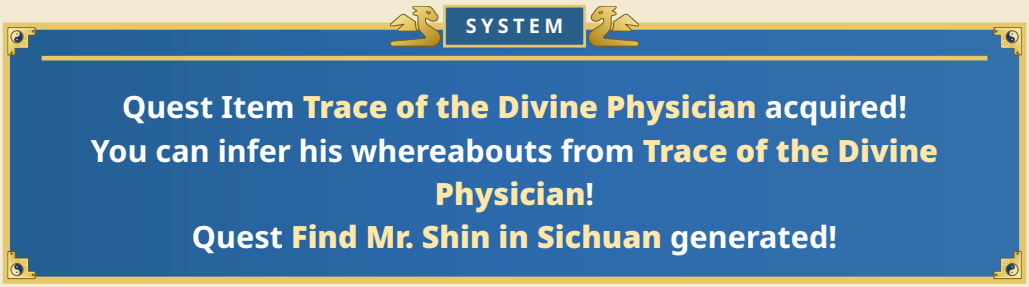
“Look closely! Can’t you feel it? The Divine Physician’s desperate desire to exchange medical knowledge with me!”

“What desperate desire…?”

I picked up the shard to examine it more closely.

At that exact moment—

Ding.



I looked at the Luoyang Strange Physician and murmured, “I can feel it. His feelings.”

And now I could see it too.

A way to treat Jeok Cheongang.

Chapter 308

"Go to Sichuan. If anyone can help him, it will be the Divine Physician."

The Luoyang Strange Physician was one of the ten greatest physicians under Heaven.

And he had spoken with absolute certainty. Find the Divine Physician. His medical skills were the best under Heaven.

There's hope.

If I found the Divine Physician, I could save Jeok Cheongang.

I looked at Jeok Cheongang, lying there as peacefully as if he were asleep, then bowed to the Luoyang Strange Physician.

"Thank you. Truly."

The Divine Physician was a man so shrouded in mystery that no one knew his identity.

Without the token of the Divine Physician that the Luoyang Strange Physician had given me, I would have felt as if I had been dropped into the middle of a vast ocean.

"Ahem. Is that all I get? Words?"

"Would you like me to bring you a souvenir?"

The Luoyang Strange Physician chuckled at my joking reply.

"You insolent brat. Instead of wasting time spouting nonsense, start packing your bags right now."

"Oh. Right."

Even by the roughest estimate, the journey from Henan to Sichuan was several thousand li.[1609] Even with my movement technique, it would take nearly a month.

And there's no guarantee I'll find the Divine Physician right away.

I looked at the Quest window, which I had not yet closed, and muttered inwardly.

[1609] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

SYSTEM

Quest
Find Mr. Shin in Sichuan
You have acquired the only trace left behind by the Divine Physician.
The Divine Physician is the greatest physician under Heaven. At present, he is the only hope capable of waking Jeok Cheongang.
You must scour the vast land of Sichuan and find him!
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Possession of **Trace of the Divine Physician**
Mission: Find the Divine Physician and receive treatment (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: Jeok Cheongang's death

Just look at that ridiculous Quest Grade.

I was looking for one person, yet the Grade was Supreme Peak.

Fortunately, the trace he'd left behind years ago had narrowed his whereabouts down to Sichuan. But the place was so damn vast that finding him would still be brutal.

Modern Sichuan Province was about twice the size of the Korean Peninsula, wasn't it?

Murim and the modern world were completely separate worlds. But from what I'd experienced so far, the size of the land and the way people lived were similar.

The thought of searching all of Sichuan for someone whose name and face I didn't even know was daunting.

Fuck. It'd probably be easier to find Mr. Kim in Seoul.

But what choice did I have? There was no decision to make. I had to find the Divine Physician, no matter what it took, if I wanted Jeok Cheongang to live.

Jeok Cheongang had six months left.

If I continued guiding qi through his acupoints, I might be able to buy him another month or two. But that was the absolute limit of the time Jeok Cheongang had left.

I'll find him before time runs out.

To do that, I needed to cut down the time the search would take. My mind raced before I finally spoke.

"May I ask you for a favor?"

It might require an enormous amount of manpower and money.

But the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, offered a solution without hesitation.

"I'll write letters to the Sichuan Tang Clan, Emei, and Qingcheng."

"Thank you."

The Sichuan Tang Clan was one of the Five Great Families. If I could also secure the cooperation of the Emei Sect and Qingcheng Sect, both pillars of the Nine Sects and One Gang, the search would become much easier.

But my request didn't end there.

"Since you're already helping me, could I ask you to add a few more things?"

"Hm. Everyone is on edge after the bloodbath at Shaolin. With Dark Heaven and the Demonic Cult believed to be on the move, they may not be able to offer much help. For martial artists affiliated with a sect, their own sect must come first."

"I don't need that much help."

"Tell me anything that I—or Huashan—can do."

"Just assign me a few people. That will be enough."

"Do you have anyone in mind?"

"Yes."

I nodded and gave him several names.

A short while later, Mae Jonghak and the Luoyang Strange Physician left the pavilion and walked along slowly as they spoke.

"Are you certain about this? I understand that meeting the Divine Physician has been your lifelong wish."

"My lifelong wish…"

At Mae Jonghak's words, the Luoyang Strange Physician gazed into the distance as he recalled the past.

"It was. He was the reason I abandoned my official post and took up acupuncture needles."

The Luoyang Strange Physician had once been a promising young scholar.

His grandfather had been the head of the Guozijian, the empire's highest educational institution, and had served as the late Emperor's tutor when he was Crown Prince.

A scholar's blood ran true. His father and two older brothers had also entered government service and made names for themselves at court.

If a plague hadn't broken out the year the Luoyang Strange Physician placed first in the imperial examination, he likely would have followed the same path.

"More people died than I could count. As my duties required, I sorted them into the dead, the survivors, and those destined to die."

As a young man newly entered into government service, the Luoyang Strange Physician had believed without question that the august Emperor would order

relief grain released and dispatch imperial physicians to bring the plague under control.

He had believed every civil and military official would do everything in their power to save the suffering people.

“I was mistaken. While the people died of plague, the Emperor expanded a detached palace for his new consort, and the powerful divided among themselves everything that should have gone to the people.”

“What did you do?”

“I wrote lies as facts. Under my brush, a hundred thousand seok[1610] of grain, wealth, and medicinal supplies became aid distributed to the sick. The imperial physicians who had been attending the scholar-officials became true physicians laboring to suppress the plague.”

“That must have been painful.”

“It was. When I returned home after leaving the palace, I found imperial physicians sent by the Emperor waiting there. They had come to treat my grandfather’s mild cold.”

That was when he first learned that the world put a price even on human life.

The Luoyang Strange Physician’s knuckles whitened around the cloth bundle containing his acupuncture needles.

“Then I heard about the Divine Physician. A physician who risked death to treat the sick at the very source of the plague. One man who brought the plague under control and saved thousands of lives.”

He immediately returned to the palace, destroyed every record he had written, and left the government.

He had to sever all ties with his family, but he didn’t care.

He traded his brush for acupuncture needles and studied medical texts instead of the Four Books and Three Classics.[1611]

“I was called a quack more times than I can count. Sometimes I saved patients already sitting at death’s door. Many other times, I failed to cure them and had to watch them go.”

As a physician, he witnessed the countless cycles of birth, aging, illness, and death.

Twenty years later, the promising young official had become known as the Luoyang Strange Physician.

“None of it would have been possible without the Divine Physician. Without him, I would have become a puppet of that rotten court.”

Mae Jonghak smiled faintly.

“So one Divine Physician gave rise to another.”

[1610] A seok was a traditional measure of grain volume, commonly about 180 L (48 US gal). A hundred thousand seok is about 18 million L (4.8 million US gal).

[1611] The Four Books and Three Classics are classical Confucian texts studied by scholars.

“What nonsense. I’m content to remain the Strange Physician. There is only one Divine Physician under Heaven.”

The eyes of the famously eccentric Luoyang Strange Physician sparkled like a boy’s.

Mae Jonghak couldn’t help laughing at the sight.

“Good grief. Perhaps I should take back the Divine Physician’s token while I still can.”

“Heaven is Heaven because it lies beyond our reach. If I truly wished to find him, I would have left for Sichuan ten years ago, when I first received the token. My place is here. Besides…”

The Luoyang Strange Physician continued with a bitter smile.

“How could an old quack who still cannot cure a single patient dare show his face before the Divine Physician? This is enough for me.”

“Thank you. With hostile forces stirring everywhere, if Great Hero Jeok recovers, the entire Murim will owe you a great debt.”

“Come now, what has gotten into you? That doesn’t suit you at all.”

The Luoyang Strange Physician waved him off with exaggerated modesty. Then a mischievous look crossed his face.

“Are you practicing in advance?”

“Practicing what?”

“Your gravitas as the Alliance Leader. Ha-ha.”

“Ah. That?”

Mae Jonghak scratched the back of his head, looking uncomfortable.

“I have no idea who keeps spreading that rumor. I’ve already turned the position down several times…”

“As things stand, no one is more qualified than you, Great Hero Mae.”

“Don’t say that. Everyone is simply anxious, and their anxiety is driving them to make the wrong choice.”

The bloodbath at Shaolin Temple had sounded the alarm.

A hidden force known as Dark Heaven had emerged.

With the appearance of an enemy whose existence had never before been revealed, the leaders of orthodox Murim had cautiously begun discussing one subject.

The re-formation of the Murim Alliance.

“Someone else is better suited to the position. At the very least, this old man is not.”

“Do you truly believe that?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician raised a hand and pointed toward the sky.

Dawn had only just broken, and the moon and stars still lingered above.

“One God has vanished, and the Ten Kings have grown old. From what I have seen with my own eyes, Great Hero Mae possesses both formidable martial arts and an upright heart. You are the man best suited to lead the Murim Alliance, the symbol of the orthodox faction.”

“Come now. I’ve already told you this old man absolutely cannot do it. With so many people in the world, why would anyone make me the Alliance Leader?”

“Then who do you believe would be suitable?”

“Hm…”

Mae Jonghak thought for a moment before answering.

“Right. Senior Peng, the Thunderbolt Saber King, is nearby.”

“His temperament is far too…”

“What’s wrong with Senior Peng? I like that fiery personality of his. He’s manly.”

“He would make a fiery wreck of the Murim Alliance. In the manliest way possible.”

“Then Senior Zhuge Gonghu would be perfect. He once served as Chief Strategist of the Murim Alliance, and his Supreme Peak immortal arts and outstanding formation techniques earned him a place among the Ten Kings…”

“He’s dead.”

“What? Since when?”

“More than ten years ago.”

“Good heavens…”

Mae Jonghak had been away for so long that he no longer knew who was alive and who was dead.

After letting out a long groan, he asked, “Do you happen to know what became of the other two members of the Three Saints?”

“The Bow Saint has also been missing for more than twenty years. As for the last one… frankly, he shouldn’t even be considered.”

“Hm? Why not?”

The Luoyang Strange Physician stared at Mae Jonghak in disbelief.

“Who in their right mind would nominate the Slaughter Saint as Alliance Leader?”

“What’s wrong with him? His martial arts go without saying, and he is thorough by nature. He would be perfect as Alliance Leader.”

“The problem is that he uses those martial arts and that thorough nature to murder people for a living. The greatest assassin under Heaven as Alliance Leader? How could that possibly work?”

“Is that so? Now that you mention it, you may have a point.”

Watching Mae Jonghak scratch vigorously at the back of his head, the Luoyang Strange Physician wondered:

Is orthodox Murim really going to be all right like this?

Meanwhile, preparations for Jin Taekyung's departure were moving at lightning speed.

The first person to come running when he heard I was leaving was Jin Wikyung.

"My youngest."

I answered while stuffing everything I needed into my traveling bag.

"Yes?"

"This eldest brother has just heard something unbelievable."

"Believe it. It's true."

"W-where did you say you were going?"

"Sichuan."

"H-how long will you be gone?"

"Six months. Maybe another month or two if it takes longer."

"No!"

Jin Wikyung cried out as if overcome with grief.

"Where are you going at a dangerous time like this?"

"Sichuan."

"I know! That is why I cannot let you go!"

"I'm still going."

With a grim expression unlike any I'd ever seen on him, Jin Wikyung declared, "I forbid it."

"Oh. Then I'll veto your veto."

"With Father away, I am both the Lesser Family Head and acting Family Head! You cannot defy my orders!"

"What happens if I do?"

"I will have no choice but to punish you according to family law."

"Then strike me from the family register."

"How can you say such a thing?"

From the look on his face, the world was going to end in ten minutes.

I left Jin Wikyung, who was reeling from the shock, and rose to my feet.

Jeok Cheongang, still unconscious, was secured to the wooden back carrier on my back with silk.

It might be too late if I find the Divine Physician and bring him all the way back here.

That was why I'd chosen this method.

I would take Jeok Cheongang to Sichuan with me.

"Heave-ho."

This should hold well enough for me to use my movement technique, at least to some extent.

I let out a deep sigh at the pleading look in Jin Wikyung's eyes.

"Don't worry so much. Nothing like what you're imagining is going to happen."

"Take the Jin Dragon Squad. At least take the Jin Dragon Squad with you."

The Jin Dragon Squad might be the Jin Family of Taiyuan's most elite force, but right now they'd only be deadweight slowing me down.

I tossed my fully packed traveling bag to one of the men nearby.

"That's why I'm taking the Vice Squad Leader with me."

Hyuk Mujin caught the bag and thumped his chest confidently.

"Leave it all to me, Lesser Family Head!"

"…"

"…Lesser Family Head?"

"Ah, it's nothing. Please take good care of my youngest."

Jin Wikyung patted Hyuk Mujin on the shoulder, looking as if he trusted him about as far as he could throw him.

That was when—

"Benefactor! When are we leaving? Huh? Benefactor?"

"…We're leaving now, so please shut your mouth."

Was bringing that guy really the right decision?

A sudden wave of regret hit me, but Cheongpung was perfect for this mission, which required a small, elite group.

At least there's no questioning his strength.

If anything went wrong on the journey, Cheongpung alone would be worth an army.

"Sichuan! The Divine Physician! This is so exciting!"

"…"

It still wasn't too late. Maybe I should just leave him behind.

Locked in a fierce internal struggle, I left the pavilion.

The final member of our party was waiting at the entrance.

"Long time no see."

At my greeting, he answered with a gloomy expression.

"Requesting me was a poor choice."

"No. You have to come with us."

"My Myriad-Li Chasing Wind Movement Technique…"

"You only learned it to the fifth stage."

"H-how do you know that?"

"…Have you learned anything past the fifth stage?"

The Oseong-and-Haneum villain.[1612]

No, the final member was Gung Gibang, the Successor Beggar of the Beggars' Sect.

Hyuk Mujin, Cheongpung, and Gung Gibang.

Now that I saw the three of them together, this lineup was no joke.

I sighed.

"All right, let's go, you three Bermuda Triangle bastards."

[1612] Oseong and Haneum were famous friends from the Joseon era. Taekyung is punning on Oseong's name and *oseong*, "five stages."

Chapter 309

It had already been three days since I left Luoyang with the Bermuda Triangle.

I suddenly opened my mouth.

“Mujin.”

“Huff, huff. Yes?”

Hyuk Mujin lay sprawled facedown over a rock beside a stream, looking ready to breathe his last.

He had made tremendous progress over the past year, but the limits of his internal energy and martial arts had quickly caught up with him.

Gung Gibang’s keeping up reasonably well, but even he’s falling short.

As befitted the Successor Beggar of the Beggars’ Sect, Gung Gibang possessed one of the finest movement techniques among the young prodigies. Even so, he was still a step below Cheongpung and me.

What good was learning the Myriad-Li Chasing Wind Movement Technique[1613], supposedly the fastest movement technique in the Beggars’ Sect, when he had only mastered it to the fifth stage?

“Gung Gibang.”

“Huff… Why’d you call me?”

His breathing was ragged.

He was in better shape than Hyuk Mujin, but he was having just as hard a time.

And then there was the last one…

“Benefactor, would you like a dumpling?”

“You eat plenty yourself.”

“I ate plenty on the way. I’m full.”

“Then take a shit and eat some more.”

“Wow! What a great idea!”

“…”

That was Cheongpung for you.

Anyone who had enough energy to stuff himself with dumplings between bursts of movement technique was a monster, all right.

Though I had no room to talk when I was in about the same shape as Cheongpung despite carrying Jeok Cheongang on the wooden frame strapped to my back.

I scratched the side of my head as I looked at the three of them.

Hmm. This isn’t going to work.

From Henan, through Shaanxi, and all the way to Sichuan.

[1613] A Chinese li (□) is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

The journey spanned several thousand li[1614]. Even on horseback, it would take at least a month.

But we didn't have that kind of time.

If we wanted to shorten the journey drastically, we needed drastic measures.

"Huff… Captain, why did you call me?"

"Oh, no particular reason."

I turned to Hyuk Mujin.

"That thing I asked you to hold on to. You still have it?"

"What thing?"

"The chain."

"What are you talking about…? Oh, that thing you used to wear with all those weights dangling from it?"

"Yeah."

It was a chain specially crafted by the Fire Gate Clan from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

Just before the Star-Array Grand Banquet began, I had removed the chain along with the iron ball. When Hyuk Mujin heard that it was made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, his eyes had lit up, and he had quickly taken it.

"You brought it, right?"

He was quick on the uptake, if nothing else.

Sensing trouble, Hyuk Mujin's eyes darted about.

"No. I left it somewhere safe."

"Really?"

"Yes."

"Then let's do this. If I search you and find it, you die."

"Ah, silly me. Now that I think about it, I did bring it."

Clink.

Only then did Hyuk Mujin begin unwinding the chain wrapped around his torso beneath his shirt.

Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron was both impossibly hard and remarkably light. Apparently, he had wrapped it around himself as makeshift armor.

It could serve as temporary armor or a weapon, and the material alone was worth an enormous fortune.

No wonder Hyuk Mujin looked as if his soul were being torn from his body as he handed it over.

"Didn't you give this to me to use? I was saving it to make a weapon later…"

"I told you to hold on to it. Did I say you could keep it?"

[1614] A Chinese li (□) is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

“You can’t just give someone something and take it back.”

“I borrowed it too. It belongs to the Fire Gate Clan. How do you think Old Master will react if he wakes up and finds you carrying it?”

“…Please take it. Hide it somewhere I’ll never have to see it again.”

“Good choice. Gibang!”

Chain in hand, I called the bewildered Gung Gibang over and got to work.

The two of them stared blankly at me, wearing expressions that clearly asked what I was doing. Then they spoke at the same time.

“What are you doing?”

“What kind of pointless bullshit is this?”

Rattle, rattle.

I answered calmly.

“Can’t you see? I’m tying a knot with the chain.”

“No, I mean, why are you wrapping it around my waist…?”

“Hold on. Untie this.”

“There. Done.”

I proudly admired the fruits of my labor.

Hyuk Mujin, Gung Gibang, and finally me. The three of us were strung together with the chain like dried fish.

“Everyone well rested?”

“What rest? It hasn’t even been fifteen minutes!”

“Untie us this instant!”

I beamed and shook my head.

At the same time, my dantian began to churn, sending ninety years’ worth of internal energy surging into my legs.

“All right. Let’s run.”

Fwoooosh!

“Waaaaagh! You lunatic!”

“The Captain’s lost his mind! He’s trying to kill me!”

Chained to me, Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin tore off like wild boars with their tails on fire.

At the commotion, Cheongpung came scrambling out of the nearby brush, where he had been relieving himself with his ass bared, and raced after us.

“Benefactor! I’m coming too!”

“…”

I don’t think that bastard wiped.

No. He must have.

I desperately pushed the thought from my mind and unleashed my movement technique.

Time flew as quickly as the scenery streaking past us, and in only two days, we accomplished the astonishing feat of reaching the border between Henan and Shaanxi.

Trudge. Trudge.

Broken ranks. Exhausted faces.

The dozens of people trudging wearily onward were all members of an Escort Bureau.

The armed escorts were exhausted. So were the caravan porters, bundled in thick clothing as they led the horses and carts.

And it wasn't merely because their trading journey had already lasted four months.

"Hwaran."

At the voice in her ear, a pair of faintly gleaming black eyes turned to the side. Her clear voice followed.

"Yes, Uncle Heo?"

"It's…"

A middle-aged man with a graying beard quietly approached the head of the procession. After a moment's hesitation, he sighed.

"Chief Escort Seok has passed away."

"…!"

The slender figure swaying gently in the saddle went rigid. A moment passed before her trembling voice emerged.

"So in the end… he's gone."

"The poison reached his marrow. There was nothing more we could do. I'm sorry."

"You have nothing to apologize for, Uncle. Brother Seok—no, Escort Leader Seok died because of me."

Ju Hwaran bit down hard on her lip beneath her veil.

It's true. Everything happened because I lacked virtue.

Escort Leader Seok, who had grown up with her like a brother, and the thirty-two people who had died before him—all of their deaths had been caused by her poor judgment.

Father. What am I supposed to do?

Ju Hwaran raised her head toward the sky.

It was black as ink, studded with countless stars. Above them, a man's face appeared in her mind.

Her father, Ju Hogun, had fallen into qi deviation while cultivating two years earlier and had hovered between life and death ever since.

To have such a beautiful and gifted daughter—this father could ask for nothing more. Ha-ha!

Ju Hogun had said it so often that it had become a habit.

Another man might have adopted a son to carry on his line, but Ju Hogun loved his beautiful and talented only daughter and had always taken pride in her.

You alone will succeed me. The Yongbong Escort Bureau's past fifty years will be nothing compared to what you accomplish in the future.

Everyone in Shaanxi knew how completely Ju Hogun doted on his daughter.

But as Ju Hwaran grew older, people realized that he wasn't simply a foolishly indulgent father.

She was brilliant enough to master the Escort Bureau's ledgers before she had even turned twenty, and beautiful enough to be named one of the Three Flowers of Jiangbei.

On top of that, she was a master of martial arts skilled enough to be counted among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, the greatest young prodigies of the orthodox Murim.

That was Ju Hwaran.

And yet…

Where did it all go wrong?

Ju Hwaran swallowed the sigh welling up from deep within her chest.

Everything around her was collapsing—and only two years had passed since she took over the Yongbong Escort Bureau in place of her stricken father.

"Hwaran, are you all right?"

At least she still had her people.

The fifty years of goodwill her grandfather and father had built through benevolence and virtue were now the only pillar holding her upright.

Ju Hwaran forced a smile at Heo Jun, the Chief Escort, who spoke to her with concern.

"You don't need to worry about me, Uncle Heo."

"I'm glad to hear it."

Heo Jun nodded, his expression somber.

Ju Hwaran was only twenty-one.

She already possessed much, but she was still too young for her heart to have hardened enough to bear it all.

Burdened by such terrible guilt, she needed someone to watch over her. That was all he could do.

Ju Hwaran understood how he felt. Steadying her voice, she said, “It’s getting dark. We’ll camp here tonight. Please make the preparations.”

“A good idea.”

“And… prepare the funeral as well.”

Escort Leader Seok was the thirty-third casualty of this journey.

It was time to lay to rest the man who had been beside Ju Hwaran since childhood.

Salt could slow the decay of his body, but by the time they completed their escort mission, the poison remaining within him would undoubtedly have reduced his flesh and bones to a handful of bloody water.

“All right. Rest here for a while.”

“Everyone else is working. How could I rest? Don’t worry about me. Go.”

Heo Jun nodded slightly and gave a hand signal. The procession soon came to a halt.

There was still a chill in the air, but the broad stretch of land was perfect for camping. Ju Hwaran planned to replenish her strength here and cross the mountain early the next morning.

We’re almost there.

Ju Hwaran stared at the mountain shrouded in darkness.

Its stones were black, giving Black Stone Mountain its name. Once they crossed it, this escort mission would enter its final leg.

They had suffered countless losses, but if the escort journey succeeded, the Yongbong Escort Bureau would have a chance to catch its breath.

It’s seven days and nights from here to Mount Zhongnan. We don’t have much time to spare, but if we make it safely across Black Stone Mountain, it should be enough.

The question was how Black Stone Mountain’s master would receive them.

Of the countless mountain strongholds belonging to the Green Forest Alliance, Black Stone Stronghold was powerful enough to rank among the Eighteen Strongholds. Its Stronghold Lord was a Peak master renowned for wielding an axe with uncanny skill.

If the travel-worn Yongbong Escort Bureau clashed with Black Stone Stronghold, they might suffer even greater losses than they already had.

Please, let nothing happen.

Ju Hwaran had just turned away when—

Rustle.

A faint sound reached her ears.

Something had stepped on a dry leaf, and it wasn’t a wild animal.

A red alarm bell instantly rang in Ju Hwaran’s mind.

An enemy!

Shing!

Ju Hwaran drew the flexible sword at her waist and shouted like a thunderbolt.

“Who’s there?”

Her sharp cry rang through the darkness.

Chief Escort Heo Jun noticed the danger almost simultaneously and led the escorts into a protective ring around her.

“Protect the Young Bureau Head!”

“Yes, sir!”

Clang, clang, clang!

Keen-edged weapons flashed beneath the dim moonlight.

At that moment, the brush more than five hundred feet away began to stir.

“Well, well. If it isn’t the brave escorts of the Yongbong Escort Bureau.”

A towering giant emerged, a huge axe strapped across his back. At the sight of him, Heo Jun let out a low groan.

“Heavenly Axe…”

“Oh, Brother Heo. I’ve heard all about how busy you’ve been wiping some little girl’s ass lately.”

“You dare!”

A graceful figure suddenly stepped forward beside the stiffly standing Heo Jun.

“Perfect timing. We were just about to pay the toll.”

“We’ll see.”

Heavenly Axe grinned and gave his axe a shake.

“Let’s take a look at the goods first. Then we’ll talk.”

Rustle, rustle, rustle!

Behind his axe, hundreds of Green Forest bandits emerged.

Chapter 310

Rustle, rustle, rustle.

Five hundred bandits emerged behind Heavenly Axe.

But their overwhelming numbers weren't the only reason Ju Hwaran's face hardened.

Their momentum is different.

Those trying to cross the mountain and those blocking their way. Escort Bureaus and the Green Forest were inseparable.

An Escort Bureau couldn't draw its swords every time it encountered bandits, so it would pay a set toll. The Green Forest, in turn, would accept a reasonable sum and withdraw, allowing both sides to save face. That had long been the custom.

But neither Heavenly Axe nor the bandits of Black Stone Stronghold showed any intention of backing down.

"You mean to spill blood after all…"

Heavenly Axe curled his lips at Ju Hwaran's words.

"You're pretty sharp for a little bitch. That's right. Today, I intend to stain Black Stone Mountain with blood."

"Little bitch?"

"What? Don't like it? Would you rather I called you an old bitch?"

"I am the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau. Show me the same courtesy I'm showing you."

Ju Hwaran's beautiful, brush-painted eyebrows shot upward.

She was the bureau chief's only child, but that didn't mean she had been raised pampered and sheltered.

She had swung a sword since childhood until calluses formed across her palms. She had eaten and slept on the road alongside the escorts, watching and learning.

People fawned over Ju Hwaran as one of the Three Flowers of Jiangbei, but she was no hothouse flower.

"What a brazen little bitch. And what will you do if I refuse?"

"Then…"

Ju Hwaran—the Dagger Hidden Flower—continued with a frosty expression.

"You'll have to die at the hands of this little bitch."

"What? Huh… Hahahahaha!"

It took a while for Heavenly Axe's wild laughter to subside.

"You've got more backbone than I expected. I like you."

"Why would I care if some old bandit likes me?"

"You've got quite the sharp tongue. Aren't you worried about what comes next?"

“Why are you doing this in the first place?”

“Why? A bandit says he intends to kill and rob you. Does he need some special reason?”

Ju Hwaran bit down hard on her lip at his brazen reply.

“If word of this gets out, it will put the Green Forest Alliance in a difficult position.”

“A difficult position?”

“The Yongbong Escort Bureau is part of the orthodox faction. The orthodox Murim won’t stand idly by.”

“Part of the orthodox faction, are you? Then I suppose that would be a problem.”

Heavenly Axe stroked his shaggy beard and continued.

“So I’ll do my best to make sure word never gets out. A secret can’t hurt anyone if it never leaks, can it?”

“…”

Silencing the witnesses.

Realizing what Heavenly Axe meant, Ju Hwaran tightened her grip on her sword hilt. Chief Escort Heo Jun stepped forward in her place and shouted, “One hundred silver nyang[1615]! Clear the road, and I’ll give you one hundred silver nyang[1616]. We’ll consider today’s matter closed, so let this end here!”

“Oh? One hundred nyang[1617]? Silver nyang[1618], at that?”

“Of course. Have I ever made an empty promise?”

“No, you haven’t. This is hardly our first meeting. Brother Heo’s word can be trusted.”

Chief Escort Heo Jun had devoted nearly thirty years to the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

The Yongbong Escort Bureau was a major Escort Bureau based in Shaanxi. Heo Jun had successfully completed hundreds of escort journeys, large and small, and crossed Black Stone Mountain so often that he had become acquainted with the Green Forest’s Stronghold Lords. That included Heavenly Axe, who had taken command of Black Stone Stronghold five years earlier.

“That’s five times the usual toll. Enough of this nasty joke. Clear the road.”

“A nasty joke? Is that what this looked like?”

Heavenly Axe let out a hearty laugh. Then his face abruptly turned cold.

[1615] A *nyang* was a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. Its value is not convertible using modern Korean won exchange rates.

[1616] A *nyang* was a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. Its value is not convertible using modern Korean won exchange rates.

[1617] A *nyang* was a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. Its value is not convertible using modern Korean won exchange rates.

[1618] A *nyang* was a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. Its value is not convertible using modern Korean won exchange rates.

"There's a limit to how much of a fool you can take me for. Brother Heo, if you want to bargain, offer a fair price."

"A-A fair price?"

"Even the dogs in my stronghold know that the goods you're transporting include a Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng. We could sell it as stolen goods today and easily get several thousand silver nyang[1619] for it. Isn't that right?"

"…"

Several people's eyelids began to twitch, including Ju Hwaran's and Heo Jun's.

A thousand-year snow ginseng was an elixir that could grant a full jiazi[1620] of internal energy if completely digested.

The existence of the thousand-year snow ginseng, which had been secretly commissioned by the Zhongnan Sect, was a top-level secret known by only a handful of people within the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

How had word reached Heavenly Axe?

None of it was a coincidence.

The past four months of the escort journey flashed through Ju Hwaran's mind.

The bandits and nameless wandering martial artists who had attacked them as if they were mortal enemies.

They had fought dozens of battles, large and small, and suffered terrible losses—all because information about the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng had leaked.

Who was it?

The thought had occurred to her before, but she had forced her suspicions down.

What had kept her going through the misfortunes that had piled upon her over the past two years was the people around her.

They were the greatest inheritance her grandfather had passed to her father, and her father to her.

Even as the Yongbong Escort Bureau lost its former glory and gradually declined, they had stayed. Despite her repeated failures, they had continued to show her unstinting trust and support.

That was why she hadn't wanted to suspect them. Why she had refused to doubt them.

But now…

Ju Hwaran swept an empty gaze over her surroundings.

Chief Escort Heo Jun stood frozen, looking as betrayed as she felt. Then she saw the other three people who knew about the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng.

[1619] A *nyang* was a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. Its value is not convertible using modern Korean won exchange rates.

[1620] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

They were the three outstanding escort captains who represented the Yongbong Escort Bureau—the men collectively known as the Dragon-Phoenix Three Escorts.

Seokchil. Noh Piljung.

Ju Hwaran's gaze passed over the two middle-aged escort captains, both nearing forty, then turned to the last man.

Song Ilseom.

Unlike the other two members of the Dragon-Phoenix Three Escorts, Song Ilseom was tall and strikingly handsome.

Barely past thirty, he had joined the Yongbong Escort Bureau as an escort ten years earlier and risen rapidly through the ranks.

Though he occasionally revealed his rough temper, his outstanding martial arts had led numerous escort journeys to success. That was why, despite his youth, he had earned a place among the Dragon-Phoenix Three Escorts.

But Song Ilseom was also the subject of endless gossip.

> "They say he used to be a wandering martial artist. A fixer, no less."

> "Apparently, there was nothing he wouldn't do as long as he got paid."

> "That's not all. Everyone says he's deeply in love with the Young Lady. Mihyang told me that whenever he gets the chance, he slips into the inner courtyard and wanders around the garden."

> "I heard he joined the Escort Bureau because of the Young Lady… Everyone knows the Chief wanted an escort as his son-in-law, after all."

Ju Hwaran knew the rumors surrounding Song Ilseom.

She also knew that most of them were true.

Song Ilseom's blatant stares had made her uncomfortable more than once. Indeed, that was why she had agonized over whether to bring him on this escort journey.

But surely Captain Song wouldn't…

The moment Ju Hwaran's gaze settled on Song Ilseom's face, his thick, fierce-looking eyebrows shot upward.

Flash—whoosh!

"Hwaran!"

Three things happened at once.

A dagger shot from Song Ilseom's sleeve.

At the same time, Chief Escort Heo Jun hurriedly stepped in front of Ju Hwaran.

And finally—

Thud!

“Ghk… Grrrk.”

More than twenty jang[1621] away, a Black Stone Stronghold bandit collapsed with the dagger buried in his throat.

Bloody foam spilled from the bandit’s mouth. He convulsed, then went still.

“…”

A frigid silence descended over the scene. It seemed as though it might last forever, until Song Ilseom shattered it with a single shout.

“No more talking! Fight as if your lives depend on it!”

His fierce cry carried far on the night wind.

Ju Hwaran, Heo Jun, and everyone else from the Yongbong Escort Bureau realized the same thing.

Negotiations were over.

Now they would have to fight to the death against hundreds of enemies who had suffered an unexpected opening attack.

“Song Ilseom! What have you done?”

At Chief Escort Heo Jun’s furious shout, Song Ilseom raised his willow-leaf saber and rested it across his shoulder.

“What do you think? It’s a little late to ask that now, isn’t it?”

“You bastard…”

“He’s right.”

Ju Hwaran spoke calmly as she gripped her sword hilt.

Unfortunately, Song Ilseom was telling the truth.

Heavenly Axe was already advancing toward them, radiating a terrifying aura.

He had lost one of his men without having time to do anything. Flames poured from his bulging eyes.

“I’ll slaughter every last one of you.”

Hissssss!

Red qi writhed along the blade of his lowered axe.

The Green Forest Alliance had countless members, but Heavenly Axe ranked twentieth among them—a Peak master.

Buoyed by their leader’s aura, the five hundred Green Forest bandits growled like wild beasts.

“Kill them all!”

“This will be your grave!”

[1621] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Twenty jang is about 60.6 meters (199 ft).

Listening to their furious cries, Ju Hwaran looked up at the star-studded night sky.

This may be my last escort journey.

Of the seventy-odd people who remained, barely forty were escorts once the caravan porters were excluded.

Everyone was exhausted from the long escort journey. The conditions were far too harsh for them to face Heavenly Axe and five hundred Green Forest bandits.

Can I do this?

Thud, thud, thud.

The ground trembled beneath hundreds of footsteps. The battle she had tried to avoid but could no longer escape was about to begin.

All we can do now is fight to the very end.

She had to get at least one person out alive.

Just as Ju Hwaran was about to face forward again, she noticed a star she had never seen before.

Among the countless stars embroidered across the pitch-black sky, one shone brighter than all the rest. It cast its radiance for the briefest moment, then vanished.

And in the next instant, something no one could have expected happened.

“Don’t fight, everyone! No matter how badly you get along, something terrible will happen if you fight!”

At the sudden shout, everyone stopped dead. Hundreds of heads whipped toward the source of the voice.

The world lay submerged in darkness.

Four figures stood atop a hill, faintly illuminated by the moonlight.

Soon, quiet voices drifted down.

“What are they?”

“They look like bandits. The people on the other side seem to be from an Escort Bureau.”

“No, I can see they’re bandits. I’m asking why they’re fighting out here in the middle of the night. We’re already busy enough to drop dead.”

“They look busier than we are.”

“Mujin, has it been long since you were hit?”

“No. About half an hour.”

Smack!

“Gibang, do you know who they are?”

“Of course.”

“Help me out, Speed Beggar.”

“Judging by the flag, they’re from the Yongbong Escort Bureau. The other side is Black Stone Stronghold, led by Heavenly Axe.”

“Never heard of either one. But for some reason, Heavenly Axe sounds familiar.”

“The Yongbong Escort Bureau was once counted among the Ten Great Escort Bureaus of the martial world, and Heavenly Axe is a Peak master ranked among the Green Forest Alliance’s top twenty. He wields a single axe like a demon…”

“No, wait. You don’t mean that Heavenly Axe, do you?”

“You know Heavenly Axe?”

“I definitely killed him… Did he catch the reincarnation bus or something? Wait here. I’m going to get a look at his face.”

“Benefactor! What’s a reincarnation bus?”

“Try crossing a crosswalk the next time you’re bored.”

The utterly incomprehensible conversation ended there.

Then a large shadow came trudging down the hill.

Only when it drew closer, one step at a time, could everyone make out what it was.

What is that?

He’s just a young punk. Why is he carrying a pack frame on his back?

It was a truly bizarre sight.

Hundreds of people facing one another in the darkness, weapons in hand.

And through their midst came a young man carrying a pack frame, strolling beneath the moonlight as if he were out for a walk.

Step, step. Stop.

“Sorry to interrupt when you’re so busy.”

The young man finally stopped and slowly turned his head.

He frowned at the grimy bandits. When his gaze reached Ju Hwaran, he suddenly began fidgeting awkwardly. Finally, he gave Heavenly Axe a quick once-over and tossed out a single remark.

“This isn’t the bastard.”

“…”

“…”

Hundreds of pairs of eyes widened at the bombshell.

He had just called Heavenly Axe—a Peak master counted among the Green Forest Alliance’s foremost experts—a bastard.

While everyone was still doubting their ears, the second bomb dropped.

“Oh, you’re that guy. The real Heavenly Axe. No wonder something seemed off. But you don’t look as impressive as the rumors made you sound either.”

Heavenly Axe finally came to his senses, his eyes blazing like fire.

“Y-You lunatic!”

The next instant, the axe in his hand crashed down toward the crown of the young man’s head.

Whoosh—crash!

Condensed qi collided.

A flexible sword intercepted the axe blade, which shimmered with red qi.

Ju Hwaran's wrist trembled as she desperately blocked the blow.

She, too, was a swordswoman who had reached the Peak. But Heavenly Axe possessed both tremendous natural strength and far greater experience. She was nowhere near strong enough to withstand him.

"Ghk! Young Hero, hurry and run—!"

"You little bitch, how dare you!"

Clang, clang, clang!

The two blades locked together, sending sparks flying.

The enormous axe slowly bore down on her.

Just as Heo Jun and Song Ilseom charged forward to help Ju Hwaran, the lips of the young man standing as still as stone parted.

"Say one thing for me."

"…What?"

"Help me. Just say those words."

Is he out of his mind?

The thought flashed through Ju Hwaran's head.

The young man had not even been able to react to Heavenly Axe's attack. If she had not blocked it with her flexible sword, he would have been cut in half and killed without a chance.

But regardless of what she thought, the words were already leaving her mouth.

"Help me!"

Then she saw it.

The faint smile forming at the corner of the young man's lips.

A voice so quiet that only she could hear it reached her ears.

"Quest accepted."

Whoosh!

A scorching wind erupted without warning.

And Ju Hwaran felt an endless warmth.

Chapter 311

"Quest accepted."

Ding.

> **System** - You have accepted the Sudden Quest **Crisis of the Yongbong Escort Bureau**!

You've really grown up, Jin Taekyung. Now you can even create Quests on your own.

I smiled proudly and extended my right hand. My palm, glowing red with the heat of the Flame Divine Palm, struck the side of the axe at terrifying speed.

Boom!

The deafening impact sent Heavenly Axe's massive body sliding backward. He staggered back three jang[1622], his face twisted with confusion and fury.

"W-What is the meaning of this…?"

"What do you think? You messed with the wrong guy."

I grinned and looked Heavenly Axe up and down.

This wasn't the fake Level 10 Heavenly Axe I'd encountered long ago. This was the real Heavenly Axe, a whopping Level 90.

Wow. The real thing really is different.

He was much larger, his face so vicious that it would have been a crime for him not to be a bandit, and his martial arts were on an entirely different level.

The sight of him brought old memories bubbling back to the surface.

I gained quite a bit of Fame when that false rumor about me taking him down spread.

That was around the time people within the Jin Family of Taiyuan began to reevaluate me.

They had mistaken the fake Heavenly Axe for the real one and spread the rumor, allowing me to gradually shed the stigma of being the family's disgrace.

Damn, it feels like yesterday.

Heavenly Axe glared at me warily as I sank into nostalgia.

"Who… the hell are you?"

"Me? The man who's going to kill you twice."

"W-What did you say?"

"It's a long story."

"Kill me twice? What kind of bullshit is that…? Wait. Could it be…?"

[1622] A jang is a Korean unit of length equal to ten cheok, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three jang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); five jang are about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

Heavenly Axe's voice abruptly cut off.

He stared at me, his face rigid. Then a thunderous cry burst from his lips.

"The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi!"

"Huh? You know me?"

"I heard a rumor like that about a year ago… No, that's not the point."

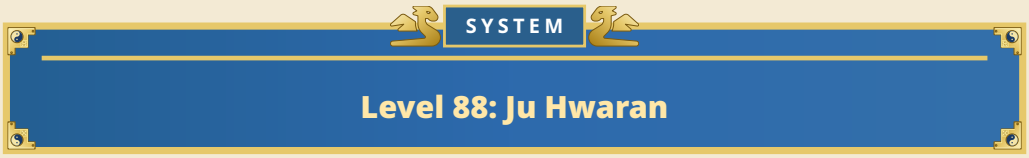
Heavenly Axe continued in a stammer, the way he addressed me already changing.

"A-Are you truly Young Hero Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"I'm not a Young Hero, but I am Jin Taekyung."

When I nodded readily, startled gasps escaped from all around us.

Bandits and escorts alike stared at me in shock. The gaze from beside me was especially intense.



Her smooth lips parted slightly, and a clear voice flowed out.

"You're… the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi?"

"Hmm. That's what people call me."

She stared up at me with wide black eyes, then abruptly gave me a formal fist-and-palm salute.

"I am Ju Hwaran, Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau. It is an honor to meet you, Young Hero Jin."

"Ah, yes. Nice to meet you."

I guess I'm more famous than I thought.

I'd never expected to run into hundreds of people who knew me on a mountain road in the dead of night, thousands of li[1623] from Shanxi Province.

Even less had I expected the most beautiful woman I'd seen in all my twenty-eight years to recognize me first.

Can a person really look like this?

There was no way to properly describe Ju Hwaran's beauty with simple words like *pretty* or *beautiful*.

I was still staring at her, cursing my inadequate vocabulary, when—

"Ahem. Come to think of it, don't we have repairs to do at the stronghold today?"

"Y-You're right, Chief. I completely forgot."

Amid awkward coughs, hundreds of bandits began cautiously edging away.

I turned to find Heavenly Axe and the Green Forest bandits of Black Stone Stronghold slowly backing off.

[1623] A Chinese li is a unit of distance equal to about 500 m (0.311 mi).

I waved at Heavenly Axe.

"Hey, Axe."

His body stiffened.

"…Axe?"

"Yeah. Our Axe. Where are you going?"

His expression was a sight to behold. It twisted, smoothed out, then twisted again. Rising fury warred with his patience, leaving his face twisted into a ridiculous grimace. Heavenly Axe barely managed to squeeze out a reply.

"I have some business to attend to at the stronghold, so I should be going."

"Exactly. Why are you leaving without permission?"

"…"

A chilly silence settled over the clearing. Heavenly Axe's hand turned white around the haft of his weapon, but that was as far as it went.

We had exchanged only a single blow.

But Heavenly Axe—and everyone else present—must have realized it. I was a master on a higher level than him.

Of course, that wasn't the only source of the fear making Heavenly Axe hesitate.

"W-Where is the Fire King?"

Where else? Sleeping soundly on the pack frame strapped to my back.

I had covered him with layers of fur in case anything happened. No one could possibly imagine that the terrifying Fire King was lying unconscious on the pack frame.

Besides, no one can find out that Old Master has collapsed.

If that happened, all kinds of vermin, including Dark Heaven, would come crawling out of the woodwork.

I concealed my thoughts and laughed quietly.

"Why do you ask about my Master?"

"I only asked because I wanted to meet him."

"Why? Are you close to my Master?"

"Well, he is someone I've always respected…"

"If you ever do meet him, don't say that. He'll be offended if a bandit bastard like you pretends to be close to him. He'll start by breaking three or four of your ribs."

"…Your joke is in poor taste."

"Does it sound like a joke?"

Heavenly Axe bit down hard on his lip and rolled his eyes.

His gaze swept over me, Ju Hwaran and the other members of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, then the faces of the Bermuda Triangle slowly descending the hill. Finally, his eyes returned to me.

“Then he isn’t here?”

“What if he isn’t?”

“If that’s the case…”

Swish. Clunk.

Heavenly Axe raised his axe and rested it on his shoulder.

“Then that changes things considerably.”

“Like the way you’re talking now?”

“It was exhausting, humoring a young punk like you.”

“That’s strange. Nothing seems to have changed whether my Master is here or not.”

“That’s because you’re a greenhorn who knows nothing about the ways of the world.”

“How so?”

“I admit your martial arts are more impressive than I expected. But don’t make the mistake of thinking you’re your Master’s equal.”

Heavenly Axe raised one hand, his face filled with contempt.

At once, nearly five hundred Green Forest bandits lifted their weapons and stepped forward.

The mere fact that the Fire King was not present seemed to have restored their confidence.

“The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, is undoubtedly a master beyond the human realm. But can you really turn the tide of this battle all by yourself?”

“Hmm.”

I looked around.

There were only a little more than seventy people from the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

Half were caravan porters who didn’t know so much as a single move of martial arts, and even the escorts who would have to fight were visibly exhausted.

By contrast, Heavenly Axe commanded nearly five hundred Green Forest bandits.

They had more than ten times as many fighters. Heavenly Axe certainly had reason to be confident.

But…

“I might as well turn it around while I have the chance.”

“Hahaha! Go ahead and try.”

“That’s the plan.”

The smile vanished from Heavenly Axe’s lips.

By then, I had already crossed five jang[1624] in a single step and thrown my fist.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Vroooom.

Compressed air exploded outward. The wind split, and Extreme Yang heat surged forward.

The same strike that had brought down an unnamed cliff on Mount Song shot toward the five hundred Green Forest bandits massed together like a swarm of ants.

Heavenly Axe stood at their head.

Baaaaang!

A roar split the sky, sending clouds of dust and steam billowing upward.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

System notifications continued boring into my ears without pause.

These bandits were too low-Level to grant me any EXP. I had neither the need nor any reason to use my spear.

I simply unleashed my martial arts indiscriminately at the enemies beyond the chaotic fog.

Baaaaang!

I tore, struck, and smashed everything in my path.

Blood and screams flooded the shattered ground as it heaved like it had been struck by an artillery barrage.

“Gaaaaah!”

“Kill him!”

“He’s over there!”

Whoooosh! Thud!

Dozens of blades came flying too late and buried themselves in the innocent ground.

Their every movement was sluggish. I could clearly see the exact path each weapon would take.

This is easy. Almost bizarrely easy.

Crack!

My own movements, by contrast, were precise and carried tremendous destructive power. Each time I pressed forward without hesitation, three or four screams rang out.

The panicked bandits could no longer distinguish friend from foe. They simply swung their weapons like madmen.

Shhk! Slash!

[1624] A jang is a Korean unit of length equal to ten cheok, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three jang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); five jang are about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

“Gaaah! You crazy bastard!”

“W-Wangpal?”

“Yeah, it’s me! It’s me, you damned bastard!”

“Sorry. I thought you were him…”

I whispered into the flustered bandit’s ear.

“This time, it is me.”

“…!”

Crunch!

I seized his neck and twisted with exactly as much force and speed as necessary.

His body crumpled without so much as a scream.

Before it touched the ground, I was already moving again.

Flamefire Path.

The Fire Gate Clan’s signature cultivation technique.

I kicked off the ground and surged forward, a tail of fire piercing the haze.

For an instant, the surroundings lit up, revealing a giant man measuring eight cheok[1625].

Our gazes met through the air.

“There you are.”

“Jin Taekyung, you bastard…”

Grind.

Heavenly Axe ground his teeth as I stepped toward him.

I unleashed the Flame Divine Palm with all my internal energy behind it.

Red qi streamed from the enormous axe Heavenly Axe brought down with the momentum of splitting a person in two.

A lionlike roar burst from his mouth.

“Die!”

Whoooosh! Boom!

An immense wave of energy whirled outward from the collision.

We were so close that I could feel his breath against my cheek. My cold, impassive face was reflected in Heavenly Axe’s bulging eyes.

So were the broken axe and my hand, which had pierced through the weapon and his chest to emerge from his back.

Fwoosh!

“Ghk…!”

No blood gushed out like a waterfall.

The heat of the Flame Divine Palm had already vaporized it.

[1625] A cheok is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Eight cheok are about 2.42 m (7.95 ft).

Heavenly Axe's lips, cracked like a drought-stricken field, moved weakly.

"Y-You… just what…"

"Why? You told me to turn things around."

Shhk.

With those words, I pulled my hand from his chest.

His entire body had been burned and melted after he failed to block the opening strike of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Heavenly Axe looked down at his charred-black chest and muttered in a broken voice.

"This… can't…"

The unfinished words became Heavenly Axe's last.

Thud.

As his eight-cheok[1626] frame collapsed, a System notification rang out.

> **System** - You have defeated **Level 93 Bangyeol**! - You have completed **Defeat Heavenly Axe**! - You have gained a substantial amount of EXP!

Whoooosh.

Just then, a gust of wind swept around Black Stone Mountain and descended into the clearing.

The pale haze scattered, revealing the scene beneath it. Everyone's eyes widened.

"This can't be!"

Bangyeol, the Heavenly Axe.

Ranked twentieth in the Green Forest Alliance, he had been a Peak master counted among the foremost of the countless Green Forest bandits scattered across the continent.

Now he was dead.

The corpses of more than a hundred bandits slain in the melee lay scattered throughout the clearing.

The four hundred survivors stared at me with fear-filled eyes.

No. Everyone who had witnessed the scene was crying out.

"The Fire King…!"

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

Fifty years ago, in an unnamed wilderness, he had annihilated a thousand Demonic Cultists—a martial artist who could stand against a thousand men alone.

The legend of the Fire Gate Clan had been proven through the Fire King's myth.

[1626] A cheok is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Eight cheok are about 2.42 m (7.95 ft).

And now, its spark had passed to me.

“Choose. Die here, or…”

My entire body burned hot. Extreme Yang heat flowed between my teeth, sending white steam billowing from my mouth.

I stared at my enemies with flames burning in my eyes.

“Kneel. Every last one of you.”

Clang.

Beginning with a single sword someone dropped helplessly, more than four hundred weapons rolled across the ground.

> **System** - You have completed **Subdue Black Stone Stronghold**! - You have successfully completed the Quest **Crisis of the Yongbong Escort Bureau**! - You have gained a substantial amount of EXP! - **Level Up!**

The cheerful chime announced the end of the battle.

Chapter 312

After the bandits of Black Stone Stronghold surrendered, the first person to collect herself was Ju Hwaran, the Young Bureau Head.

She regarded me with an indescribable look in her eyes, then gave me a deep fist-and-palm salute.

“We owe you an immense debt.”

“It was nothing. I was passing by anyway, so I took care of it while I was here.”

I meant it. I had already been on my way through, and it hadn’t taken long. The Level I’d gained was more than enough compensation.

From Ju Hwaran’s perspective, though, I must have seemed like a lifeline.

“If not for Young Hero Jin’s help, every member of the Yongbong Escort Bureau would have left their bones here. I had heard much of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi’s fame, but it seems the stories of you being a hero who cannot abide injustice were true.”

“A hero? Hardly. That’s just a rumor people spread because it sounds good.”

“Pardon?”

“I can ignore injustice sometimes. I only get rid of people who annoy me every now and then. It just so happens that the people who annoy me are always scumbags—like that Heavenly Axe bastard.”

I glanced at Heavenly Axe’s corpse as a caravan porter dragged it away, then continued.

“And my family runs an Escort Bureau too.”

“Ah, the Jin Family Escort Bureau.”

The Seongun Escort Bureau, once run by the Woo family, had changed its sign to the Jin Family Escort Bureau and was thriving. I’d heard it already had more than five branches.

Shaanxi and Shanxi shared a border, so the Jin Family Escort Bureau and the Yongbong Escort Bureau would probably cross paths someday.

“You know about the Jin Family Escort Bureau. If you ever run into them, please treat them well. Fellow business owners should help each other out, just like today.”

“Fellow business owners?”

“Is there a problem?”

“You do know that the Jin Family Escort Bureau and the Yongbong Escort Bureau are competitors, don’t you?”

Huh? We were competitors?

I blinked and asked again.

“Is that true?”

"You really didn't know?"

"No. I barely pay attention to family affairs."

"If you hadn't saved us today, the Jin Family Escort Bureau might have been able to expand into Shaanxi Province. We may not look like much right now, but we still dominate Shaanxi."

"I see."

"This line of work is more cutthroat than it looks. There are plenty of struggles behind the scenes, and armed conflicts break out from time to time."

"Well, so what if we can't expand? I'll tell my eldest brother we should get along with you."

Ju Hwaran stared at me with an odd expression before letting out a quiet laugh.

"I'd appreciate that."

Wow. I almost gasped out loud.

All she had done was laugh. How could that be so beautiful?

I swallowed the exclamation rising in my throat just as murmuring voices reached me from behind.

"My word. That's the first woman I've ever seen who's more beautiful than Young Lady Lee Seowol."

"Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran is one of the Three Flowers of Jiangbei. I don't know who Lee Seowol is, but how could she possibly compare?"

"As if you're one to talk. Gung Gibang, go scrub yourself on a rock in the stream. That grime is so filthy it makes me sick."

"What's wrong with me?"

"You're a beggar, aren't you?"

"Hah. That's true, I suppose."

An innocent voice followed.

"That's not true. Young Lady Lee Seowol is pretty too."

"What's gotten into Cheongpung? I didn't know you could say things like that."

"And Gung Gibang looks pretty to me too."

"…Then go wash up in the stream with pretty Gung Gibang. Pay special attention to your eyes."

There was no need to look. It was the Bermuda Triangle.

Normally, I would have at least introduced them, but the level of their conversation was so low that I was embarrassed to say anything.

I was forcing out an awkward cough when Ju Hwaran poked her head past my shoulder.

"Who are those people?"

"I don't know."

"You came here together."

“They’re just traveling companions.”

“Really?”

“I swear it on the heavens.”

I had lowered my voice as much as I could, but the Bermuda Triangle still overheard me. They erupted like wildfire.

“Captain! Are you ashamed of us?”

“Am I embarrassing?”

“Benefactor! I’m fine! Please be ashamed of me!”

“…They’re actually my friends.”

“Anyone can see that.”

Anyone can see that? Somehow, that was even more devastating.

Ju Hwaran laughed softly at my expression, then gave the three of them a fist-and-palm salute.

“I am Ju Hwaran, Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau. It is an honor to meet my Benefactors.”

I wasn’t sure what those three had done to deserve being called Benefactors, but the Bermuda Triangle bowed their heads anyway.

“I am Hyuk Mujin, one of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan’s foremost elites, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad, and the right-hand man of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.”

I calmly corrected him.

“Not the Vice Squad Leader—the acting Vice Squad Leader. And he isn’t my right hand. He’s more like the pinky on my left.”

Gung Gibang spoke next.

“I am the beggar Gung Gibang.”

“He’s the next-generation beggar boss.”

Finally, it was Cheongpung’s turn.

“Hello! You’re pretty!”

“As you can see, he’s a little unwell. He may not be the sharpest, but he’s a good friend.”

After the whirlwind of introductions and my helpful explanations, Ju Hwaran’s lips parted slightly.

Her large black eyes practically quaked.

“So, let me make sure I understand… The pinky on your left hand, the next-generation beggar boss, and the slightly dim but kind friend?”

“Yes, exactly.”

“I’ve never heard anyone introduced that way before.”

“Would you like me to repeat it?”

"No, thank you."

She let out a deep sigh, then studied them one by one.

"I, too, have heard of the Swift Wind Sword, who rendered distinguished service during the campaign against the northern mounted bandits."

"…Huh?"

Hyuk Mujin stared at Ju Hwaran in bewilderment.

Swift Wind Sword?

I had no idea when he had acquired such a sobriquet, but judging by his reaction, it seemed to be real.

Before anyone could respond, Ju Hwaran continued.

"And the gentleman beside him is Young Hero Gung Gibang, the Successor Beggar and Disciple of Great Hero Myriad-Mile Pursuit, the Beggars' Sect Leader."

"P-Pleased to meet you."

"Lastly, it is an honor to meet Young Hero Cheongpung, the Huashan Divine Dragon. My grandfather and father always spoke of Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint, as a hero of benevolence and righteousness."

Huashan Divine Dragon was the sobriquet people had given Cheongpung after the Star-Array Grand Banquet.

Cheongpung's eyes widened in surprise.

"Wow! How do you know all that?"

Ju Hwaran smiled brightly.

"Because I'm the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau."

The answer was brief, but it said a great deal.

We had left Henan only a few days after the Star-Array Grand Banquet ended.

She gathers information quickly.

Unlike Cheongpung and Gung Gibang, Hyuk Mujin was an unknown newcomer who had operated only in Shanxi Province.

The fact that she knew both his name and his sobriquet so precisely meant that Ju Hwaran was even more meticulous and clever than I had expected.

Dagger Hidden Flower. A flower hiding a dagger.

And she had more than one dagger hidden away: Peak-level martial arts, a keen mind, and beauty that could captivate anyone.

She more than deserved her place among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, the martial world's foremost young prodigies.

Interesting. With all that, she should be good at running an Escort Bureau too.

According to Gung Gibang, however, the past two years had brought the Yongbong Escort Bureau one hardship after another.

I shook the question from my mind.

Eh, what difference does it make if I worry about it?

Finding the Divine Physician was more urgent.

We had already lost nearly a shichen[1627] here. If we wanted to reach our destination before dawn, we needed to get moving now.

“Young Lady Ju, I think we should be going.”

Ju Hwaran flinched at my sudden declaration.

“Now?”

“I have something urgent to take care of.”

“It’s already so late. Why don’t you spend the night here and leave in the morning…?”

“That might be difficult… We need to reach Xi’an by tomorrow.”

“Ah.”

Ju Hwaran hesitated as though she had something to say, then finally spoke.

“Will I be able to see you again?”

“Of course. If fate brings us together.”

I lowered my head and was about to turn away when Ju Hwaran called after me.

“I will never forget the debt I owe you for saving our lives.”

“I’m not so sure about that. Even if I hadn’t been here, you would have avoided the worst, so you don’t need to be that grateful.”

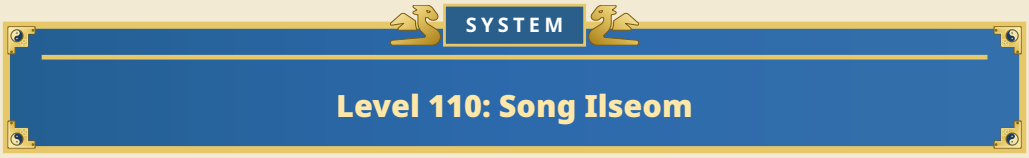
“What?”

“You would have suffered some losses, of course.”

She still doesn’t know?

Well, that was understandable.

I smiled at the bewildered Ju Hwaran, glanced at the fierce-eyed young escort, and turned away.



The Murim really is a vast place. Someone that skilled is working as an escort?

He was the source of the gaze I’d felt this entire time.

Thanks to him, the back of my head had prickled the entire time I was speaking with Ju Hwaran.

But why has that bastard been glaring at me like that? Did I somehow become his sworn enemy?

Apparently, I wasn’t the only one who had noticed his hostile gaze. Cheongpung followed close behind me and whispered.

“Benefactor, did you feel it too?”

[1627] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"Yeah. I don't know why he's acting like that, but he's being incredibly obvious."

"Right? Maybe he's interested in Benefactor."

"…"

Please stop talking bullshit.

The four figures shot away like the wind. As Ju Hwaran watched their backs recede, someone approached her.

"Hwaran."

"Ah, Uncle Heo."

Heo Jun had finished binding the bandits and dealing with the aftermath. He followed Ju Hwaran's gaze and turned his head.

"Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. He truly is an extraordinary young man. The others are no different."

"I know. They say rumors from the martial world can't be trusted… but in this case, they seem to have understated the truth."

Ju Hwaran recalled the martial prowess Jin Taekyung had displayed.

It had been an overwhelming sight. Watching him had sent a thrill through her, but it had also left her bitter.

If only I had strength like that.

If she had, the Yongbong Escort Bureau would never have ended up in its current state.

Ju Hwaran swallowed the words on the tip of her tongue and spoke. This time, she sent them through Sound Transmission, carrying them on her internal energy.

—Uncle Heo. Keep an eye on Escort Captain Song.

Heo Jun was seasoned enough to be the Chief Escort. Without revealing anything on his face, he brought up another subject and replied through Sound Transmission.

—Hwaran. Are you suggesting…?

—It's only a suspicion for now. But too many things don't add up.

The leak of confidential information about the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng. The attacks that had continued without pause for the past four months.

Ju Hwaran intended to cut out the betrayal that had taken root deep within the bureau.

Especially the last thing Jin Taekyung said.

He had said that even without him, the worst would never have happened.

That meant there was a master within the Yongbong Escort Bureau capable of easily defeating Heavenly Axe and handling the enemies.

And… that look in his eyes.

It had lasted only an instant, but she had seen it clearly.

Jin Taekyung's gaze had lingered on Song Ilseom as he turned away.

And his eyes had held a faint trace of surprise.

There's definitely something going on.

Ju Hwaran suddenly thought back over the past two years—the countless failures she had endured while leading the Escort Bureau before she had even turned twenty.

What if those failures had come from trusting people too easily? What if someone had betrayed her?

What was she supposed to do then?

Whoooosh.

As the cold wind whipped around her, Ju Hwaran stood there for a long time.

"Could you provide me with a quiet room?"

The man was dressed in white. He was strikingly handsome, and his words and manner were so courteous that anyone who heard him would find it difficult to refuse.

He brought to mind a proud, solitary crane, and the Captain of the Guards standing at the entrance found himself wondering.

Who is he? I've never seen him before.

Xi'an Tower was, as its name suggested, one of Xi'an's foremost pleasure houses.

Staying there required not only money, but also the status to match. As a result, its guests tended to be the same familiar faces.

But he's a young man who came alone, without a carriage or servants…

Under normal circumstances, he would have been turned away without a second thought.

Yet something about the young man nagged at him. That was why the Captain of the Guards had dismissed his subordinates and come to receive him personally.

"Have you visited our pleasure house before?"

"No. My circumstances don't permit such luxuries."

The young man smiled sheepishly and rubbed his cheek.

The Captain of the Guards' eyes widened.

That's…!

Pale crimson blossoms had been embroidered on the young man's snow-white sleeve.

They were unmistakably plum blossoms in full bloom.

A stammer slipped from between the guard captain’s lips.

“M-May I ask your honored name?”

“I’m a Daoist named Baek Museong.”

“H-Huashan’s Lone Crane!”

Baek Museong, direct Disciple of Huashan Sect Leader Heavenly Sword True Person, smiled faintly.

Chapter 313

Huashan's Lone Crane, Baek Museong.

There was no one in Shaanxi—or anywhere in the Murim—who didn't know that name.

Baek Museong was the direct Disciple of Heavenly Sword True Person[1628] and had been called the future of Huashan since childhood.

Sharp-eared, gossip-loving busybodies traded rumors about the Sword Saint's youngest Disciple, but even they never doubted that Baek Museong would one day become the Sect Leader of Huashan.

"I hear the Huashan Divine Dragon's martial prowess has already surpassed that of the Elders of the Nine Sects and One Gang.[1629] He truly is a genius who comes along perhaps once in a century."

"Even so, no matter what anyone says, Huashan's Lone Crane is bound to be the next Sect Leader. Baek Museong is simply of a different caliber. He was born with everything a Sect Leader needs."

"That's true. Does he lack martial skill? Character? If not him, who else could possibly become Sect Leader?"

The people drinking and chatting on the first floor of Xi'an Tower had no idea that the subject of their conversation was passing right behind them.

"I've long heard of your renown, Great Hero Baek. It's an honor to meet you."

"Great Hero? Please, you flatter me."

"Not at all. I'm merely calling a Great Hero a Great Hero. How could that possibly be flattery?"

Baek Museong could only smile awkwardly at the Captain of the Guards' fervent gaze.

Such attention was nothing new to him.

As Huashan's standing rose after faltering in the wake of Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's withdrawal from the world, so too did the burden on Baek Museong's shoulders grow heavier.

The Sect Leader.

For Baek Museong, who was only in his early thirties, it was a distant and weighty title.

He was inwardly shaking his head at the thought when the Captain of the Guards stopped walking.

"This is the place."

"This is…?"

[1628] "True Person" is a Taoist honorific for a spiritually accomplished person.

[1629] A traditional grouping of nine major martial sects and the Beggars' Sect.

“Even in Xi’an Tower, which we proudly call the finest establishment in Shaanxi, there is only one private annex.”

Baek Museong looked around at the garden adorned with jade and the interior filled with luxurious furnishings, his expression troubled.

“I’m sorry, but I don’t have enough money on hand to stay in a private annex. Could you provide me with a quiet room instead?”

“Haha, you’re every bit as frugal as I heard.”

The Captain of the Guards continued with a hearty laugh.

“Please don’t worry. The proprietor has repeatedly instructed us that whenever a guest from Huashan arrives, we are to provide the utmost hospitality and charge them nothing.”

“The proprietor said that?”

“Yes. There was some trouble with the Zhongnan Sect last autumn, but it was resolved with Huashan’s help. The other two members of the Three Plum Blossom Elites—your Junior Brothers—played a major role.”

“Ah, I see. It happened while I was in secluded training, so I knew little about it.”

“To be honest, I only heard about it myself. I’ve barely been working here a month. Haha.”

Only then did Baek Museong nod in understanding.

It wasn’t as though he had spent the past year idling.

Meeting Cheongpung, a prodigy for the ages, and Jin Taekyung had come as both a tremendous shock and a fresh source of motivation. That was why Baek Museong had decided to enter secluded training for an entire year.

It was time well spent.

The insight he had gained during his training had made him stronger and given him greater depth.

And he wasn’t the only thing that had changed. Huashan’s position was now incomparable to what it had been a year ago.

Even the government offices, which were heavily staffed by Zhongnan’s lay Disciples, now turned to Huashan first whenever trouble arose.

If Master’s letter is true, that’s only natural.

Five days earlier, a messenger eagle sent by his Master, Heavenly Sword True Person, had brought astonishing news.

The blood calamity at Shaolin. The death of Dharma King Hong Dao. And the report that Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was being considered as a candidate for the Alliance Leader of the new Murim Alliance, which was being revived after decades.

“In any case, everyone around me is in an uproar. Even my friends have been asking me about it. They say their children seem to have a talent for martial arts

and wonder whether they might be accepted into Huashan, if only as lay Disciples.”

Baek Museong recognized the meaning behind the Captain of the Guards’ pointed gaze and smiled bitterly.

The man looked well past forty. He, too, must be a parent who wanted his child to enter Huashan.

But Baek Museong pretended not to notice.

“Well, if fate brings them together, perhaps it will happen. But does a child truly need to learn martial arts? At that age, growing up healthy is enough.”

“…I see.”

As the Captain of the Guards’ face fell, Baek Museong murmured inwardly.

If you knew about the bloody storm that will soon sweep in, you wouldn’t look so disappointed.

Rumors about the blood calamity at Shaolin had already begun to leak out here and there.

But the existence of Dark Heaven remained a top-secret known only to a handful of people. As one of those few, Baek Museong could sense what was coming.

A bloody wind would soon sweep through the Murim. Dark clouds would cover the sky, and thousands upon tens of thousands of weapons would tumble across the ground alongside their owners.

The wails of children who had lost their parents and parents who had lost their children would echo from every direction.

I’ll stop that from happening. I will—and Huashan will.

Surely everyone in the Murim felt the same.

The Captain of the Guards was tilting his head at the sudden heaviness in Baek Museong’s expression when—

“Where is the chief manager? Chief Manager!”

“Young Hero, the chief manager has stepped away for a moment. So please, calm yourself—”

“Calm myself? After being treated with such disrespect, do I look like I’m in any state to calm down?”

“A-as I explained, the private annex is already occupied. We’ll show you to a special room, so please calm down.”

“Shut up! I must have the private annex today, so get out of my way!”

“Oh, Young Hero!”

Bang! Crack!

The shouting drew closer amid the clamor. The Captain of the Guards knitted his brows.

"I apologize for showing you such an unpleasant scene. It seems my subordinates have failed to handle the matter properly."

"Please, think nothing of it. I understand completely."

No matter how carefully Xi'an Tower selected its guests, it was still a pleasure house. All sorts of insects were bound to swarm a flower garden.

"Still, it's barely noon, and he already sounds quite drunk."

"It happens from time to time. He appears to be the son of some powerful family, but we'll settle the matter and send him home. Great Hero Baek, you needn't concern yourself."

Baek Museong let out a hearty laugh and shook his head.

"Haha, I'm not so sure. You'd better remain here."

"Pardon?"

"He doesn't seem to be an ordinary scion of a powerful family."

"What do you mean…?"

The Captain of the Guards faltered. Amid the continuing uproar, he had sensed someone approaching rapidly.

A martial artist!

As the situation grew more serious by the second, the cries of the guards protecting the inner courtyard rang out alongside hurried footsteps.

"Stop!"

"You cannot pass beyond this point!"

Xi'an Tower was frequented by high officials and powerful nobles, so the quality of its guards was correspondingly high. Yet even those battle-tested First Rate martial artists were no match for the drunken man's rampage.

"You lowly Third Rate trash from wandering martial artist backgrounds dare…"

"Gah!"

Whoosh! Thud-thud-thud!

Short cries of alarm from the guards and the fast, powerful sounds of impacts rang out. In an instant, the area outside the private annex fell silent.

Then rough, unsteady footsteps began to approach, driving the silence away.

He took down six First Rate martial artists in an instant while that drunk?

A master—and not just any master. A Peak master.

Just as the Captain of the Guards' face hardened and his hand moved toward his sword hilt, Baek Museong gave a small shake of his head.

"I think I should handle this."

"Great Hero Baek, that's…"

"It's all right. We've met several times before. He'll back down for my sake, if nothing else."

"You mean…?"

“Our connection goes back several generations. Ah, of course…”

Baek Museong scratched his cheek and added,

“It isn’t exactly a harmonious connection.”

“…!”

At that moment, a thought flashed through the Captain of the Guards’ mind like lightning.

First came the words *Zhongnan Sect*. Then the name of a man.

“C-could it be?”

He had only been the Captain of the Guards at Xi’an Tower for a little over two weeks, but he had already heard so many rumors about that man that his ears ached.

A man whose temperament was as extraordinary as the sect he came from.

The Captain of the Guards grimaced and was about to speak the man’s name when —

Boom!

The door of the private annex, made from sturdy blackwood, exploded. Splinters flew in every direction.

Baek Museong smiled faintly at the young man approaching with a staggering gait and a face flushed red with alcohol.

“It’s been a long time. Have you been well?”

At the same moment—

“Why are you here?”

The face of Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan One Dragon,[1630] twisted like that of a fiend.

“Wow! Wowww!”

“Please stop shouting. Everyone’s staring.”

“Benefactor! Candied fruit over there!”

“That damn candied fruit. Aren’t you sick of it yet?”

“No!”

“Then just open your own shop!”

“Can the candied-fruit vendor come with us all the way to Sichuan?”

“No, you lunatic…”

“They sell thin noodles over there! They say the broth is made with beef!”

Cheongpung, you little bastard. You’re like a rubber ball that could bounce off in any direction without warning…

[1630] A sobriquet for a leading young martial artist of the Zhongnan Sect.

I quickly grabbed Cheongpung by the back of his neck as he scampered toward a roadside food stall.

“Please, let’s just act like human beings. That’s all I’m asking. Like human beings!”

“Candied fruit… thin noodles…”

“Just wait a little longer, and I’ll feed you until your belly bursts!”

“Really?”

“How many times do I have to say it? So please shut your mouth and follow me quietly, okay?”

Of course, I wouldn’t be feeding him with my money. It would be Huashan’s money, but that was all the same in the end.

We were supposed to pass straight through here, too.

According to our original schedule, there hadn’t been any need to stop in Xi’an at all.

But before we left, Heavenly Sword True Person, the Sect Leader of Huashan, had asked us to stop by Xi’an. Since it was Cheongpung’s hometown, we had decided to pass through while we were at it.

We had been pushing ourselves for nearly seven days and nights without eating or washing properly. I also wanted to enjoy some hospitality and get at least one full day of rest.

I was told Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong, would be waiting for us.

It had already been more than a year since I’d last seen him.

Before I left for Anhui with Jeok Cheongang, Baek Museong had said this to me.

“Contact me whenever you come to Shaanxi. I’ll treat you properly. Haha.”

When he promised me the full course, I’d wondered if the guy was from Busan,[1631] but apparently it hadn’t been empty talk.

At least, judging by the fact that we were meeting like this today.

“By the way, where’s Xi’an Tower?”

A passerby I’d stopped had told me we only needed to follow the main road straight ahead. But why was the street so crowded? I couldn’t see the end of it.

As I looked around, a finger caked in black grime pointed toward a building in the distance.

“That is Xi’an Tower.”

“Where? Oh, you’re right. How did you know?”

Gung Gibang, the future boss of all beggars, answered proudly.

“It is the finest place to beg. Even the food they leave behind and throw away is fit for a sumptuous feast, and because people of high status come and go, they give plenty of alms. Every beggar knows this place.”

[1631] Busan is a port city in southeastern Korea. The “full course” quip alludes to an elaborate itinerary of local hospitality.

"…"

So it was a Beggars' Sect hotspot.

I shook my head and headed toward Xi'an Tower.

When we reached its enormous main entrance, wide enough for ten people to pass through at once, a guard who appeared to belong to Xi'an Tower bowed his head.

"I'm sorry, but we're closed today."

"…What? Is it a day off?"

"Not exactly. A slight problem arose during business hours."

"Oh."

I hadn't expected that.

I glanced to the side and saw Cheongpung looking as though he was about to burst into tears.

Scratching my head, I spoke to the guard.

"Isn't there any way around it? We had an appointment today. His name is Baek Museong. I was told you'd know him if I gave you his name."

"Again, I'm sorry, but at the moment— Excuse me? Did you say Great Hero Baek Museong?"

"Yes. Baek Museong, Huashan's Lone Crane."

Cheongpung called out desperately.

"Martial Nephew Baek! Where are you, Martial Nephew Baek? Can you hear my stomach growling?"

The guard looked back and forth between us, then flung open the tightly closed main gate.

"I'll escort you to the private annex immediately!"

What the hell?

Why the sudden change in attitude?

Did Baek Museong stand us up?

My guess was wrong.

We followed the guard as he raced ahead almost fast enough to fly and arrived at a nearly devastated private annex.

Baek Museong was waiting for us there, sword drawn.

Wow. This really is the full course.

This kind of shit makes me sick of being a martial artist.

Chapter 314

I stared blankly at the scene before me.

The spacious room had been reduced to a wasteland. Amid the wreckage stood two young men facing each other. No—three, if I counted the middle-aged man whose face had gone deathly pale.

What am I looking at here?

The answer came quickly.

What else? The same sight I saw practically every day.

An argument and a fight. At this point, I was starting to think they were essential virtues for any martial artist.

After taking stock of the situation, I muttered, “You’ve really laid out a full-course feast.”

Baek Museong quietly lowered his sword and gave me an awkward smile.

“You came.”

“You told me to come, so here I am. Now I already want to leave.”

“It’s been a long time. But where are the others…?”

His gaze swept over my shoulder. He couldn’t possibly be looking for Gung Gibang or Hyuk Mujin. He was obviously searching for the Martial Uncle who was the bane of his existence.

But Cheongpung and the rest of the Bermuda Triangle had vanished without a trace.

I thought they were following me quietly.

Please, just don’t cause any trouble.

I rubbed between my eyebrows. Never mind the Bermuda trio—the immediate problem was right in front of me.

“Is that what matters right now? Is causing trouble a Huashan specialty?”

“There was a minor complication.”

“You don’t need to explain. Anyone can see that.”

Suppressing a click of my tongue, I looked at the young bastard facing Baek Museong.

Sharp eyes and a shovel chin. Every young prodigy I’d met around here had been handsome or beautiful, which had left me feeling relatively deprived. But this guy was on the ugly side, so I immediately felt a certain kinship with him.

“Hello.”

They said you couldn’t spit in a smiling face.

The bastard responded to my friendly greeting.

“Get lost. A beggar like you has no place here.”

I turned to Baek Museong.

“Young Hero Baek, who the fuck is this bastard?”

“He is Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan One Dragon.”

“This bastard is a dragon too? Why the hell are there so many dragons?”

“He is known throughout the martial world as the Zhongnan Sect’s greatest prodigy and one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

“He looks more like an earthworm.”

An ugly bastard with an ugly personality. That pissed me off twice as much.

At my mutter, Hyuk Sopyung’s eyebrows shot up.

“Well, look at this son of a bitch…”

“Better than being worse than a dog. And think carefully before you swing that sword. This is the greatest crisis of your life.”

Hyuk Sopyung’s hand twitched. The blade that had been inching toward me stopped and slowly lowered. He looked me up and down with blazing eyes.

“You’re no ordinary man.”

“Yep. I’m pretty extraordinary.”

“I thought you were merely a hide peddler… But then again, Huashan’s Lone Crane wouldn’t bother with someone like that.”

“Unlike you, Baek Museong gives everyone the time of day. And look at these beautiful muscles. Do you think you can build muscles like this by selling hides?”

Admittedly, I looked like a mess.

I had charged straight ahead for more than seven days and nights without stopping at an inn even once. My hair was slick with oil, and the martial uniform that had once been clean had long since become coated in dust.

The finishing touch was the wooden pack frame piled high with hides. Jeok Cheongang’s small figure was hidden inside it.

Looking shabby is one thing, but I do smell a little.

It was about time I washed.

Hyuk Sopyung glared at me as I pressed my nose to my uniform and sniffed.

“Stop fooling around and state your sect and name.”

“God, it’s always ‘sect this, sect that’ with you people. Don’t you ever get tired of it?”

“I can promise you one thing. Unless you belong to the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families, you won’t walk out of here in one piece.”

“Really?”

I made a show of shuddering.

“What am I going to do? My sect belongs to neither the Nine Sects and One Gang nor the Five Great Families. Can’t you just let me walk out anyway?”

“You should have watched your mouth. Remember that your paltry three-inch tongue has placed both you and your sect in danger.”

“My sect is actually in a bit of trouble already. There are only two of us, including me.”

“Two?”

“Yep. My Master and me. That’s it.”

A sneer tugged at Hyuk Sopyung’s lips as he turned to Baek Museong.

“To think you would waste your time on some nobody from a Third Rate sect. You must have far too much time on your hands. Wouldn’t you be better off spending it practicing your martial arts?”

“I’m not so sure. I believe there are several problems with what you just said.”

Baek Museong continued with a pleasant smile.

“First, Jin Taekyung’s sect is not Third Rate, nor is he a nobody. Second, you are one step beneath me. That has remained true from the day we first met until now.”

“What did you just say?”

“I said you are one step beneath me. Seeing you cause a drunken disturbance like this, I suspect that will remain true in the future as well.”

His lips were smiling, but his eyes were not.

There was something in Baek Museong’s gaze that had nothing to do with martial arts.

The aura—or perhaps the dignity—that belonged to him as a person.

That seemed to be part of the reason Hyuk Sopyung could only grind his teeth without daring to answer.

And people like him always try to settle things with their fists when they run out of words.

Just like now.

The tip of Hyuk Sopyung’s sword trembled. Before he could make his move, I spoke.

“I’m pretty sure I already warned you. Think carefully before you swing that sword.”

Whoosh.

Hyuk Sopyung whipped his head toward me, his eyes gleaming with murderous intent.

“You…”

“I believe all things are equal, so I don’t usually split hairs over this stuff. But you should be grateful you’re a Disciple of the Zhongnan Sect. If you weren’t, you’d already have been carried out of here.”

Dark Heaven was gathering like a storm cloud in the distance.

At a time like this, when the Murim needed to unite just to stand a chance, starting a dispute with the Zhongnan Sect was obviously a terrible idea.

Though it might already be a little late for that.

I already had bad blood with the Zhongnan Sect.

As Three Hands of Zhongnan—and as the Roaring Fury Swordsman.

Old Master thoroughly thrashed him and sent him packing a year ago.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman wasn't some nameless nobody rolling around in the street. He was an Elder of the Zhongnan Sect and the Senior Brother of the Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord. From what I'd heard, the fallout had been considerable.

Apparently, the Roaring Fury Swordsman had entered secluded training for some reason, while the Three Hands of Zhongnan had been slapped by their Sect Leader.

That's already a perfectly good grudge. There's no need to take it any further.

The smell of the oil Jeok Cheongang had poured all over the Zhongnan Sect hadn't even faded yet. I had no desire to set it on fire.

Especially not while Jeok Cheongang was unconscious.

"So put your sword away and go quietly. Okay?"

Good job. This is how you become an adult.

It was such a calm response that I wanted to praise myself.

But Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan One Dragon, disagreed.

His teeth ground together, and his eyes flashed.

"Then let's see whether your skills can match that mouth of yours."

Hissssss!

The sword in Hyuk Sopyung's hand tore through the air at blinding speed.

At the same moment, a net of Sword Energy swept toward me.

It was the same martial art that the Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il, had unleashed a year ago.

Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords.

The Zhongnan Sect's signature technique.

Jeok Cheongang had told me that once someone reached the ultimate level of the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords, a single swing could fill heaven and earth in every direction with Sword Energy.

But…

"You know what?"

Whoosh!

Flamefire Path.

The Fire Gate Clan's signature movement technique, passed down for hundreds of years, became a single streak of flame.

I tore through the net of Sword Energy and reached my target without hesitation. Staring into Hyuk Sopyung's wide eyes, I whispered, "You and I are on completely different levels."

"…!"

Hiss—grab!

Hyuk Sopyung hurriedly altered his sword's path, but I caught him by the wrist.

The Extreme Yang qi concentrated in my hand made a sizzling sound as his flesh burned.

"Gaaah!"

A single scream burst from his lips.

The sword slipped from Hyuk Sopyung's grasp and rolled across the floor with a metallic clatter.

Before it could even hit the ground, my palm connected with his cheek.

Smack!

Once more.

Smack!

And one more time.

Smack!

Hyuk Sopyung staggered after taking three slaps without the slightest chance to resist.

Even without putting any internal energy into the blows, my physical abilities had long since surpassed human limits. His eyes were already half-unfocused, as though his soul had fled his body.

"What was it you said earlier? You wanted to see whether my skills could match my mouth?"

"Ghh… Ghhhhh…"

"Listen, you idiot. If you're from the Zhongnan Sect, then I'm from the physical school. Next time, choose where you're going to lie down before you stretch out your legs. Got it?"

Tap, tap.

I patted Hyuk Sopyung's cheek. Only then did his eyes finally regain their focus.

"H-how could you overcome the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords at seven-tenths mastery so easily…?"

"You've only mastered seven-tenths of it? No wonder it felt so half-assed. Get it to at least nine-tenths before you come at me again. I've already faced it once, so the result will probably be the same, but still."

"You've faced the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords at n-nine-tenths mastery?"

"I have. I even dodged it."

“That’s impossible! Fewer than five people in our sect have reached nine-tenths mastery!”

“I’m talking about one of those five. I heard he’s one of the top three masters in Zhongnan.”

I let out a quiet laugh and continued.

“The Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il. I wonder how the old man is doing these days. He didn’t look too well when he was humiliated and sent packing last year.”

That was answer enough.

Hyuk Sopyung was a Direct Disciple of Zhongnan’s main lineage, as well as the man called the sect’s greatest prodigy. There was no way an insider wouldn’t know a rumor that had even reached outsiders.

Hyuk Sopyung’s bloodshot eyes widened, and his body began to tremble.

“Then could you be…?”

“About what I said regarding my sect—every word was true. It isn’t one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, and its only members are my Master and me. I don’t know what possessed them to make the sect rules that way, but with only one successor per generation and a ban on teaching the unworthy, they’re damn strict.”

“The Fire Gate Clan…!”

“Disciples! There are two of them!”

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi—you’re Jin Taekyung!”

“Jin Taekyung! That’s right!”

I yanked him closer by the collar and shouted. Hyuk Sopyung’s face turned deathly pale.

After watching his expression for a moment, I grinned and gave his crumpled collar a few brisk pats.

“You know what our Master’s temper is like, right? Let’s end this here without any hard feelings. What was the phrase? Right. Let’s bury this matter forever.”

“…”

“Strange. No answer. Maybe you’ll be able to hear me after about ten slaps.”

I slowly raised my palm.

Hyuk Sopyung flinched reflexively and clenched his teeth.

“I… understand.”

“Hm? What was that? I can’t quite hear the voice of a loser who’s only mastered seven-tenths of the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords.”

“…I said I understand.”

“Good. Watch yourself on the way out. I won’t see you off.”

Crack.

The bones in Hyuk Sopyung’s tightly clenched fist creaked.

After glaring one last time at me, Baek Museong, and the middle-aged martial artist whose identity I didn't know, he strode toward the door of the private annex.

Just as he was about to leave, Baek Museong spoke.

"I'm reminded of a boy I met at a Huashan–Zhongnan gathering ten years ago."

"…!"

"Take care, Sopyung."

Hyuk Sopyung froze at Baek Museong's calm voice. Then he left the private annex without another word.

Hyuk Sopyung's presence receded into the distance.

At the same time, someone began creeping toward us.

"Come out."

At my words, someone sucked in a startled breath.

A moment later, Cheongpung poked his head out, his cheeks puffed up like a squirrel's.

He gulped down the food in his mouth, glanced around nervously, and bowed to Baek Museong.

"I'm really sorry about last time, Martial Nephew Baek…"

I suddenly remembered what had happened a year ago.

While Cheongpung was being forcibly escorted back to Huashan, he had beaten Baek Museong and the Three Plum Blossom Elites before escaping.

So this is a meeting between the perpetrator and the victim.

That bastard is guilty, no question.

Chapter 315

Step. Step.

The Zhongnan One Dragon, Hyuk Sopyung, walked neither quickly nor slowly.

With every step, people's gazes and whispers followed him.

"Tut-tut. Causing a scene like that in broad daylight…"

"To think that's the man they call his sect's greatest young prodigy. Tells you all you need to know about the Zhongnan Sect. No wonder Huashan has always been the greatest sect in Shaanxi."

"Why is his cheek so swollen? I heard Huashan's Lone Crane was here. Could it be…?"

Hyuk Sopyung unconsciously rubbed his cheek.

The throbbing pain wasn't only from the stinging gazes around him. The three slaps he had taken without being able to resist—and one man's low voice—came vividly back to him.

I thought I told you. Think carefully before you swing that sword.

The Fire Gate Clan successor chosen by the Fire King Jeok Cheongang. A Hidden Dragon who had risen from the small stream that was Shanxi Province.

Hyuk Sopyung had already heard enough about that bastard to last him a lifetime.

But…

How can he be that strong?

He couldn't understand it. He had become the direct Disciple of the Zhongnan Sect's Sect Leader and studied martial arts with the sect's full support.

Countless Peak martial arts and elixirs, even his place among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes—Hyuk Sopyung had taken them all for granted.

But now, everything around him was beginning to totter.

The cold expression on the face of Xi'an Tower's chief manager when they met at the entrance was only one sign.

"I heard you caused another disturbance."

"A disturbance? There was a little commotion, that's all. It was nothing serious, so let's forget about it."

Hyuk Sopyung was about to walk past him when the chief manager's next words stopped him dead.

"I believe I told you last time that if this happened again, I would file a formal complaint with the Zhongnan Sect."

"A complaint?"

Hyuk Sopyung glared at the chief manager, his eyes gleaming.

"Our Manager Song has grown quite bold."

"Young Hero Hyuk!"

"Don't get cocky."

A growl slipped between Hyuk Sopyung's clenched teeth.

"You seem awfully full of yourself just because the owner's son joined Huashan as a lay Disciple… Do you really think the Great Zhongnan Sect is such a joke?"

"You go too far."

Hyuk Sopyung twisted his lips at the chief manager's stiff expression.

"You're the ones going too far. A pack of wine sellers dares to look down on our sect? You've got more nerve than sense."

"May I repeat those words to the owner exactly as you said them?"

"Don't forget. Be sure to tell him. Then I'll see you next time."

Pat, pat.

Hyuk Sopyung patted the chief manager's shoulder and walked away with a bitter smile on his lips.

Now even people like him are looking down on me.

Of course, Xi'an Tower's owner possessed considerable influence for someone who could be called a mere businessman. He was a major player who controlled the entertainment district of Xi'an, the capital of Shaanxi Province.

But no matter how powerful someone was in the business world, before the name of the Nine Sects and One Gang, he was nothing more than a firefly before the sun.

And now Hyuk Sopyung had suffered such humiliation at the hands of a mere pleasure-house manager—not even the owner himself.

Things really are going from bad to worse.

Over the past year or two, the Zhongnan Sect's standing had plummeted again and again.

The first shot had been fired by the Fire King Jeok Cheongang when he crushed the Roaring Fury Swordsman in front of countless witnesses. Then came the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's return from seclusion, followed by the name Huashan Divine Dragon.

How could two tigers live on the same mountain?

One had to be the strong one, and the other the weak.

The Zhongnan Sect's role was the latter.

It won't always be like this.

Blood trickled from Hyuk Sopyung's tightly clenched fist.

He had expelled the last of the previous night's alcohol from his body long ago. He was staring up at the sky with a grim expression when—

"Gasp, gasp. Senior Brother, there you are."

"You're… Bong-su?"

Hyuk Sopyung looked at the familiar face in surprise.

The young man was panting heavily. Like Hyuk Sopyung, he was a Disciple of the Zhongnan Sect. Though they had different Masters, they belonged to the same generation.

“What brings you here when you should be at the main sect?”

The main sect stood on Mount Zhongnan, two days from Xi’an. Bong-su, Hyuk Sopyung’s Junior Brother, answered.

“I’m carrying out a mission. The entire Taeeul Sword Unit came with me.”

“A mission? The Taeeul Sword Unit too?”

The Taeeul Sword Unit was a fighting force composed of the Zhongnan Sect’s second-generation Disciples. Though they couldn’t compare to Huashan’s Plum Blossom Swordsmen, they were still an elite unit the Zhongnan Sect took great pride in.

For the Taeeul Sword Unit, who rarely even left the main sect, to come all the way here…

Hyuk Sopyung frowned in puzzlement. His Junior Brother spoke.

“I was ordered to bring you back, Senior Brother.”

“Ordered? Who’s looking for me?”

“Senior Martial Uncle is in Xi’an.”

“…!”

Hyuk Sopyung’s eyes widened. There were only two people his Junior Brother, who was of the same generation as him, could call Senior Martial Uncle.

One of them, the Roaring Fury Swordsman Song Il, had shut himself away at the main sect because of the internal injury he had suffered at the Fire King’s hands. That left only one person.

But why is he in Xi’an…?

Hyuk Sopyung hurriedly pushed the question from his mind.

If his Second Martial Uncle was looking for him, he couldn’t afford to delay for even a moment. Hyuk Sopyung feared the man more than he feared his own Master, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord.

And it wasn’t only Hyuk Sopyung. Every Disciple of the Zhongnan Sect felt the same way.

The anxiety on his Junior Brother’s face was proof enough.

“Senior Brother, there’s no time.”

“Take me to Senior Martial Uncle at once.”

A short while later, Hyuk Sopyung shot forward at tremendous speed using his movement technique. One question kept circling through his mind.

What on earth is going on?

One thing was certain.

If his Second Martial Uncle, the Taeeul Merciless Sword, had stepped in, this was no ordinary matter.

True Qi Guidance was a dangerous and difficult undertaking.

Even when circulating one's qi alone, there was always a risk of qi deviation. True Qi Guidance required circulating someone else's qi for them, so its difficulty needed no explanation.

Especially when that someone is the Fire King.

The tension was on an entirely different level from when I had performed True Qi Guidance on the Peace Guild members.

Feeling as though I were stepping onto thin ice, I began moving the Scorching Yang Qi.

Slowly. Carefully.

I repeated those two words over and over. Allowing myself no distracting thoughts, I drew in Jeok Cheongang's immense qi.

Whoooong.

The two streams of qi met.

But there was none of the collision or resistance I had encountered with the Peace Guild members. They simply blended together naturally.

They merged and yielded to my guidance as though they had always been one—as naturally as twins reuniting after a long separation.

Because they grew from the same root.

That was right. Jeok Cheongang and I shared the same root: the Fire Gate Clan.

If someone who hadn't learned the Fire Gate Divine Technique had rashly attempted True Qi Guidance, they might have failed to withstand Jeok Cheongang's immense internal energy and fallen into qi deviation.

What a relief.

I had already done this several times, but it never stopped being terrifying.

With my heart in my throat, I began the True Qi Guidance in earnest.

Following the formula of the Fire Gate Divine Technique, I ceaselessly circulated the Extreme Yang qi that had now become one.

One shichen,[1632] or perhaps two.

I lost all sense of time in my concentration. The True Qi Guidance, which had seemed as though it would never end, finally came to a close when all the internal energy returned to the dantian.

Chime.

[1632] A traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

> **System** - **True Qi Guidance** successfully completed! - The target's condition has improved slightly! - Your **Scorching Yang Qi** has increased slightly!

"Phew…"

I closed my eyes and steadied my breathing.

It wasn't over yet. For one brief moment, I had merged with the immense qi of the Supreme Peak master known as the Fire King Jeok Cheongang and felt it as my own.

The root called the Fire Gate Clan. The trunk of the great tree that had grown from it, and its countless branches. I had clearly witnessed a glimpse of an unimaginably distant realm.

Insight came from experiences and circumstances like this.

Just like now.

I'm finally starting to see the way forward.

I could see them—the steps leading to a higher realm.

It was a small insight no one could have taught me.

Chime.

> **System** - The realm of **Fire Gate Divine Technique** has risen to seven stars! - You can manipulate, release, and withdraw qi more freely! - You can now perform the martial arts of the **Fire Gate Clan** with greater power and effectiveness! - You have acquired a large amount of EXP and Bonus Points as a reward for your enlightenment! - Level Up!

Yes. This was it.

I opened my eyes to the cheerful chime. I had climbed only a single step, but the difference was immense.

Through my newly sharpened senses, information about everything around me came flooding in.

My entire body was drenched in sweat. The impurities I had expelled reeked. And someone was struggling silently behind me.

"…"

What the fuck?

I turned my head and saw Cheongpung wrapped around Hyuk Mujin's entire body like an anaconda, both hands clamped firmly over Mujin's mouth and nose.

"What are you doing over there?"

Cheongpung answered brightly.

"Hyuk Mujin was about to snore, so I was stopping him!"

"Ah, well done. That bastard nearly pissed me off so badly I fell into qi deviation."

I told that idiot Hyuk Mujin to stand guard, and he was off dreaming the Butterfly Dream.[1633]

I stared at Hyuk Mujin, whose face had turned blue as he struggled, and suddenly thought of something.

“You only need to cover his nose. Why are you covering his mouth too?”

“When I covered his nose, sounds started coming out of his mouth!”

“Oh.”

“So I covered both!”

“Hmm. Won’t he suffocate and die?”

“He can use the Turtle Breath Technique!”

“What exactly is this damn Turtle Breath Technique?”

“You hold your breath, stop your heartbeat, and lower your body temperature at the same time!”

“Sounds incredible. Is that even possible?”

“Of course. That’s what Hyuk Mujin is doing right now!”

“Mujin is?”

“Yes! His heartbeat has already stopped.”

“…?”

My brain stopped working.

I stared silently at Hyuk Mujin. While we had been talking, he had stopped struggling, and his limbs now hung limp.

“Gasp! Mujin!”

“He’ll be cold soon!”

“Get your hands off him right now, you lunatic!”

“Huh? Maybe it isn’t the Turtle Breath Technique. Young Hero Hyuk? Can’t you hear me? Young Hero Hyuk?”

I didn’t know about the Turtle Breath Technique, but the Ghost Technique certainly seemed accurate.

Just before Hyuk Mujin could achieve Great Completion in the Ghost Technique, I slammed a palm into his chest.

“Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation Fist!”

Thud!

With the dull impact, a harsh breath burst from Hyuk Mujin’s open mouth.

“Gahk!”

“Oh no, Mujin! My left pinky!”

“Cough, cough! C-Captain?”

“Are you all right? Can you breathe?”

[1633] A reference to Zhuangzi’s famous dream of becoming a butterfly.

“What?”

Hyuk Mujin looked around in confusion. Maybe because he had been attacked in the middle of his sleep, he didn’t seem to understand what had happened.

“What’s going on? I was just on a cloud.”

“A cloud?”

This idiot had really almost died.

I was letting out a sigh of relief when Hyuk Mujin continued.

“A man in white came over and started saying strange things. Something about a little lamb having come.”

“What kind of lamb?”

“A little lamb. Then he tried to embrace me, but there were holes this big in both his palms. I was about to cut him down without mercy when I woke up.”

“…”

Why was that person there?

Just as I found myself at a loss for words, the door to our private room at Xi’an Tower slid open, and a grimy face poked inside.

Gung Gibang looked over the dejected Cheongpung, Hyuk Mujin, who had just returned from the dead, and finally me, still shell-shocked.

Then he muttered, “What a kennel.”

Being treated like a dog by a beggar left a bad taste in my mouth.

After barely pulling myself together, I asked Gung Gibang, “Were you out begging?”

Gung Gibang shouted indignantly, “What are you talking about? I’m on my way back from our sect’s Xi’an branch!”

The previous night, I had decided to spend a day at Xi’an Tower and recover from the fatigue of our journey. I had also asked Gung Gibang to gather information, so he must have visited the Xi’an branch for that reason.

Since beggars were scattered throughout the world, the Beggars’ Sect had branches everywhere.

In terms of sheer numbers, it was the greatest sect under heaven.

“So? Did you find anything useful? Something about the Divine Physician’s whereabouts, for example.”

“I did. Though it wasn’t about the Divine Physician.”

Gung Gibang thought for a moment before continuing.

“This information reeks to high heaven.”

“More than you?”

“…”

“Sorry. Tell me.”

Deeply offended, Gung Gibang refused to open his mouth until I had given him five silver nyang in alms.[1634]

[1634] A traditional silver currency unit.

Chapter 316

Gung Gibang carefully tucked the silver nyang[1635] into his clothes before speaking.

“It’s about the Yongbong Escort Bureau.”

“The Yongbong Escort Bureau? You mean the one we ran into on the way here?”

“That’s right. Its operations are limited to Shaanxi Province now, but it was once one of the largest escort bureaus under Heaven.”

“The Yongbong Escort Bureau?”

I thought back to what I had seen two days ago.

For a mere escort bureau, they certainly had an impressive fighting force. Their Young Bureau Head, Ju Hwaran, was a skilled swordswoman worthy of her place among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, while an escort named Song Ilseom was at least a cut above her.

Counting the old man who looked like he could have written the Donguibogam, that made three Peak masters.[1636]

That put them on par with most well-established mid-sized sects.

But compared to their glory days, when they had ranked among the top three escort bureaus under Heaven, what I had seen that day was downright shabby.

“What the hell happened to leave it in that state?”

“It started right after the Escort King passed away.”

“The Escort King? The one I know?”

“There can’t be two Escort Kings under Heaven. Great Hero Ju Gongsan—the Escort King you know—was the previous Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau.”

Escort King Ju Gongsan.

I hadn’t known his name, but I had heard his sobriquet plenty of times. I had been around the Murim long enough by now to pick up a decent amount of general knowledge.

Besides, I had spent the past year practically joined at the hip with the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

He was a living witness to history—and occasionally an old man who reminisced about the past.

Come to think of it, that friend of mine, the Escort King, was quite something too.

He’s not your friend.

It hasn’t been that long since you tasted the Flame Divine Palm, has it?

Please tell me more. I’ll listen with rapt attention.

[1635] A nyang is a historical Korean unit of currency. Here, it refers to a silver coin.

[1636] *Donguibogam* is a famous Korean medical text compiled in the seventeenth century.

The story Jeok Cheongang had told me that day about the Escort King had been quite moving.

It was when the Great Faction War was at its height. By then, the Demonic Cult had seized eight provinces, including Gansu, Sichuan, and Yunnan, and was advancing into the Central Plains with a hundred thousand demonic soldiers.

When does the Escort King show up?

It hasn't been that long since you tasted the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, has it?

Please continue. I'm begging you.

In any case, the Escort King was nothing more than a wandering escort at the time. Of course, his remarkable skill and chivalrous spirit had already earned him some renown. But with the Demonic Cult sweeping across the world, do you think the orthodox martial artists had time to care about that?

True. Strictly speaking, escorts belong more to the business world than the Murim.

The Demonic Cult needed money as well, so rather than oppressing escort bureaus and merchant groups, they chose to win them over. Given the circumstances, it wasn't particularly strange that the Escort King of those days was in Guangdong, which was under the Demonic Cult's control. Everything went smoothly until he met a woman who was about to give birth.

A woman about to give birth?

She carried the last seed of the Guangdong Chen Family in her womb. The family had already been wiped out for resisting the Demonic Cult more fiercely than anyone else.

They must have been found almost immediately.

The Escort King only realized the truth after he encountered a Demonic Cult pursuit squad. If he refused to hand over the woman, he would have to make an enemy of the Demonic Cult.

At the time, the Demonic Cult had already swallowed half the world after winning battle after battle, Jeok Cheongang had said.

Worse still, Guangdong Province lay tens of thousands of li[1637] from orthodox territory. It was nothing short of the Demonic Cult's lair.

What do you think the Escort King did?

If he'd handed the woman over to the Demonic Cult, he wouldn't have been the Escort King.

Correct. He flatly rejected their demand. His reason was simple: he had already been paid the escort fee.

On a day when the world was engulfed in war, the young escort began what might have been his final escort mission.

Tucked inside his clothes was the old jade hairpin the woman of the Guangdong Chen Family had given him as payment.

[1637] This uses the Chinese *li*: one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

I heard it took him two whole years.

From Guangdong through Jiangxi and Hubei, all the way to Henan, where the Murim Alliance was located.

The young escort crossed half the continent while evading his pursuers. He climbed mountains, raced across fields, and swam through rivers.

No one knew how he had done it or how many dangers he had overcome, but one thing was certain.

The young escort had completed an escort mission without precedent in the history of the Murim.

When his footsteps finally reached Henan, the last seed of the Guangdong Chen Family was crying lustily in the woman's arms, and the escort Ju Gongsan had become the Escort King.

The Martial God said that he truly deserved to be called a king. No one disagreed.

Jeok Cheongang brought up the Escort King from time to time after that.

Even Jeok Cheongang, who looked at the world with a jaundiced eye, seemed to consider the Escort King a decent man.

I heard he founded an escort bureau in his hometown of Shaanxi after the Great Faction War ended… I don't know what became of him after that. Perhaps I should stop by someday and share a few drinks with him.

In the end, Jeok Cheongang's wish would never come true.

According to what Gung Gibang had just told me, Escort King Ju Gongsan was already dead.

The continent sure is small.

To think the Yongbong Escort Bureau we had encountered by chance two days ago was the legacy of that very Escort King.

Noticing the interest in my eyes, Gung Gibang continued.

"Great Hero Ju Gongsan couldn't hold out for long after the internal injuries he suffered during the Great Faction War, and passed away. It was a tragic thing."

"Then who's the current Bureau Head?"

"Great Hero Ju Hogun, the Junzi Sword.[1638] He's the Escort King's only child and Young Lady Ju Hwaran's father."

"Junzi Sword, huh? That sobriquet alone gives me a pretty good idea of what he's like."

"I've never met him myself, but… my Master said the man himself was a very good person."

A single particle could change the feeling of someone's words entirely.

Gung Gibang's Master, the Beggars' Sect Leader, hadn't simply said that Ju Hogun was a good person.

[1638] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

He had said that Ju Hogun was good *as a person.*

That reeks of a sucker.

I had a feeling the Junzi Sword's personality had played a major part in reducing the Yongbong Escort Bureau to its current state.

Sure enough, Gung Gibang read my expression and nodded.

"As you guessed. Great Hero Ju is sentimental and can't stand by when he sees injustice, so he's suffered tremendous losses in various ways since taking over the Yongbong Escort Bureau."

"He was in the wrong line of work from the start."

"My Master once said that a chivalrous hero could never be a merchant."

He was right. To be called a chivalrous hero, you had to disregard profit. To become a successful merchant, you had to pursue it more fiercely than anyone else.

An escort bureau might stand at the intersection of the Murim and the business world, but in the end, it was much closer to the latter.

One hundred points as a chivalrous hero. Zero as a merchant.

The Escort King had managed to catch two rabbits at once and build the Yongbong Escort Bureau into one of the five largest in the industry because of his fame.

But that advantage must have vanished after his death. Ju Hogun lacked the makings of a merchant, and there was no way he could make up the difference.

"Whenever a great famine struck, he would exhaust his own grain stores, then pay a premium to buy even more and give all of it away. He took in poor children and orphans, fed them, and gave them places to sleep…"

"At that point, isn't he basically UNICEF?"

"Huh?"

"Nothing. Keep going."

"In any case, more money went out than came in, and the Yongbong Escort Bureau gradually began to decline. Because of his ties to the previous Bureau Head, my Master advised him several times, but apparently, he refused to listen. Great Hero Ju insisted that this was his policy."

"Wow."

He was certainly an admirable and respectable businessman. It was just a shame he wasn't a capable one.

Gung Gibang scratched vigorously at his back as he continued.

"What could anyone do? With a man like Great Hero Ju inheriting the escort bureau, it was bound to shrink drastically in the span of thirty years."

"Thirty years? They say even a ruined rich family lasts three generations."

"It would have lasted three generations easily—if Great Hero Ju hadn't collapsed from qi deviation two years ago."

"…What's that supposed to mean? Is this the Yongbong Escort Bureau's age of tribulations or something?"

"Considering all the misfortunes they've suffered over the past two years, you could certainly call it that."

"Good grief. They must have been through a lot."

For an instant, Ju Hwaran's spirited figure flashed through my mind.

At the time, I had thought only that she was smart and pretty. As it turned out, she was a young woman carrying an entire household on her shoulders.

But…

"What exactly is this stink you keep talking about?"

Gung Gibang had started the conversation so ominously that I had listened closely, but the only foul smell around here was the stench coming off that bastard.

My fastball, aimed tight and inside, made Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin—who had been listening in silence—crane their necks forward.

"That's right. I don't smell anything. I want to smell the stink too!"

"Young Hero Gung, when was the last time you brushed your teeth?"

When the man who had nearly killed someone and the man who had nearly died asked in unison, Gung Gibang scowled.

"Oh, shut up with all that yapping."

"Never mind that. Hurry up and tell us. And don't open your mouth so wide. Seriously, when did you last brush your teeth?"

"Four months ago."

What a filthy bastard.

I stared at him as if he were some kind of animal. Gung Gibang flinched and hurriedly spat out a name.

"Z-Zhongnan Sect."

"Huh? Zhongnan Sect?"

"According to what our Xi'an branch uncovered, there are signs that the Zhongnan Sect was deeply involved in the downfall of the Yongbong Escort Bureau."

"Good grief. Those bastards stick their noses into everything."

So this really was information that stank.

No wonder the stench had hit me the moment I heard the words *Zhongnan Sect.*

For a moment, I wondered if it was because Gung Gibang had opened his mouth too wide. But judging by the conduct of every Zhongnan Sect member I had met so far, this wasn't a rumor. It was a fact.

"They're trying to swallow the Yongbong Escort Bureau whole, aren't they?"

"Swallow it whole? Is it tasty?"

"Cheongpung, could you shut your mouth for a moment?"

"Yes, Benefactor!"

By now accustomed to all of this, Gung Gibang answered as if nothing had happened.

“Most likely. Zhongnan operates an escort bureau of its own, but it can’t compare to the Yongbong Escort Bureau’s position within Shaanxi. From Zhongnan’s perspective, the Yongbong Escort Bureau must be a thorn in its side, just like Huashan.”

“So they’ve been methodically bringing it down for the past two years?”

“Young Lady Ju Hwaran is certainly talented, but she has far too little experience. Being as softhearted as her father is another weakness.”

So she was smart, but naive.

Then again, from what I had heard, Ju Hwaran was only twenty-one.

At that age, she had enough on her plate just digesting everything she had learned. Adapting to real work while leading an escort bureau of that size couldn’t have been easy.

Especially with the Zhongnan Sect pulling dirty tricks behind the scenes.

Zhongnan might have been beneath Huashan, but it was still one of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

The Yongbong Escort Bureau might have withstood its pressure while the Escort King was alive, but in its current state, it didn’t stand a chance.

Zhongnan would nibble away at it little by little until it finally collapsed.

“How widely known is this?”

“It’s top-secret information from the head of our Xi’an branch.”

“Top secret, huh? Then Huashan doesn’t know either?”

“Who knows? They might, or they might not. Even if they do, they could pretend otherwise and let it slide.”

“Pretend they don’t know? What’s that supposed to mean?”

Gung Gibang hesitated for a moment, then answered with a sigh.

“Because they’re both part of the Nine Sects and One Gang.”

“…What?”

“Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong, is an upright and honorable man. The Sword Saint, Great Hero Mae Jonghak, is as clear as a stream, and so is Cheongpung standing here. But remember—it’s foolish to judge the whole by a single facet.”

That one sentence saw straight through me.

I was leaving today anyway. I had been planning to discreetly tip Baek Museong off.

He was someone I knew to be a good man. And he held enough standing to be called the future of Huashan.

But I had been wrong.

The future is only the future. It isn't the present.

Once again, I realized that the Murim was more complicated than I had thought.

Even the world of ignorant, simple-looking swordsmen had rules—and a league of its own.

I guess an arm really does bend inward.[1639]

When I remained silent, Gung Gibang cautiously watched me and asked,

"What are you planning to do?"

"What do you mean, what am I going to do?"

"Are you… thinking of stepping in yourself?"

"Me?"

I considered it for a moment, then shook my head.

My encounter with the Yongbong Escort Bureau had been nothing more than chance. I had my own responsibilities.

"If I run into them before I leave, I can give them a heads-up. But that's it."

Now that Jeok Cheongang had collapsed, getting entangled with the Zhongnan Sect would complicate matters.

For some reason, Ju Hwaran's face rose in my mind. I shook my head and let the thought slip away.

[1639] A Korean idiom meaning that people naturally favor their own side.

Chapter 317

"Ah."

Sunlight broke across Ju Hwaran's long, fluttering eyelashes. Even after waking, she lay in bed for a long while, staring at the ceiling.

The night before, she and the Yongbong Escort Bureau had finally reached Xi'an.

Black Stone Stronghold, led by Heavenly Axe, had been the final obstacle on their escort mission.

They had passed through Xi'an's safe, bustling streets and unloaded their baggage at a secluded inn. Beds, warm food, and hot bathwater had all been waiting for them.

After checking every item in the shipment, Ju Hwaran had collapsed into sleep.

At last, the end is in sight.

This place was safe. There were no bandits blocking the mountain roads, nor wandering martial artists concealing their identities and attacking in groups. Once they delivered the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng—the primary objective of this escort mission—to the Zhongnan Sect, it would all be over.

The Yongbong Escort Bureau would receive the reward its efforts deserved, and they would all return home together.

Along with thirty-three funerary urns.

Thirty-three…

Ju Hwaran's eyes suddenly flickered faintly.

Thirty-three bone urns. Thirty-three faces. Memories of laughing and crying with them flashed before her eyes.

"Ah, I shouldn't be doing this…"

Ju Hwaran rubbed at the corners of her eyes with her sleeve, then slapped both cheeks hard. The sharp crack brought her scattered thoughts back, if only a little.

"This is only the beginning. I have to keep my head."

The escort mission was not over yet.

Three days remained until the deadline agreed upon with the Zhongnan Sect, and the mission would not be complete until the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng had been safely delivered.

"And then… it'll be a new beginning."

Muttering softly, Ju Hwaran reached inside her robes. She pulled out a tightly sealed wooden casket, checked it, then put it away again and secured it with a cord.

Just that brief exposure left a cool fragrance lingering at the tip of her nose before it faded.

Inside the casket was the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, an ancient elixir coveted by every martial artist in the Murim.

“Stay focused, Ju Hwaran. You’ve only taken the first step.”

That was when someone spoke from outside the door.

“Hwaran, are you awake?”

It was a familiar voice. Ju Hwaran straightened her clothes before answering.

“Yes, Uncle Heo. You may come in.”

“Then excuse me for a moment.”

A moment later, Chief Escort Heo Jun opened the door and entered with a bright expression.

“We’ll be able to return to the Escort Bureau sooner than expected.”

“You mean…”

“The Zhongnan Sect is waiting in Xi’an.”

“The Zhongnan Sect?”

“That’s right. And I hear the Taeeul Merciless Sword himself has come. Hahaha.”

Unlike Heo Jun, who was smiling, Ju Hwaran’s gaze sank deeply.

The Zhongnan Sect? And the Taeeul Merciless Sword came all the way to Xi’an himself?

Their return had been moved forward, so she should have been happy, just like Heo Jun.

But the more she thought about the arrogant, discourteous attitude the Zhongnan Sect had shown them until now, the more unease crept up from the depths of her heart.

“Uncle Heo, don’t you think something is strange?”

“Hm? What do you mean, strange?”

“There are still three days until the agreed-upon deadline.”

“Only three days. Even traveling slowly, it takes no more than two to get from Xi’an to Mount Zhongnan.”

“You used to say it all the time, Uncle. There are no coincidences in the Murim. It’s a place where nothing should surprise you, no matter what happens.”

“Hwaran, what are you trying to say?”

Under Heo Jun’s utterly baffled gaze, Ju Hwaran spoke gravely.

“The Zhongnan Sect has been quietly hostile toward the Yongbong Escort Bureau all this time. They must have wanted this escort mission to fail more than anyone. That’s why they deliberately imposed such difficult conditions.”

“But we accepted them. And we’ve performed admirably.”

The conditions demanded by the Zhongnan Sect had been extremely difficult. The other heads of escort bureaus who had flocked there, lured by the Zhongnan Sect’s

reputation, had even shaken their heads emphatically and abandoned the commission.

If they failed to transport the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng within the specified period, the mission would be deemed a failure, and they would have to pay an astronomical penalty.

But after much deliberation, Ju Hwaran had accepted the Zhongnan Sect's commission.

For one reason alone: to raise the Yongbong Escort Bureau to greater heights.

And we had to pay a terrible price for it.

Something that should never have happened had happened.

Information about the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng had been leaked.

Ju Hwaran was not a fool. She simply lacked experience. She possessed a sharp mind capable of considering every possibility and keeping all options open.

The suspicions she had kept buried until now were slowly taking shape. Ju Hwaran spoke quietly.

"Perhaps… perhaps the Zhongnan Sect…"

"Enough."

Heo Jun cut her off, his face hardening.

"Stop. I know what you're thinking, but anything beyond that is absurd. No—it's dangerous."

"But—"

"I know the rumors about the Zhongnan Sect. It's also true that they've been keeping us in check so they can expand their own escort bureau. But what you're suggesting, Hwaran… is dangerous speculation."

"Uncle Heo…"

"As your uncle and as the Chief Escort of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, I'm asking you. Don't put yourself or the bureau in danger."

Though they shared not a drop of blood, he was an uncle who had always treated her warmly, ever since she was a child.

When he deliberately poured out those words with such a stern expression, Ju Hwaran could no longer continue speaking about the Zhongnan Sect.

"Phew."

As Ju Hwaran let out a quiet sigh, Heo Jun gently put an arm around her shoulders.

"I'm sorry if I was too harsh."

"No. I suppose I was being overly sensitive."

"You had reason to be. The Zhongnan Sect did something it had never done before. Who would have expected them to send the Taeeul Merciless Sword instead of a Hall Master or Chief Steward?"

The Taeeul Merciless Sword was one of the Zhongnan Sect Leader's two Senior Brothers.

He normally remained at the main sect and rarely showed himself in public. There was one simple reason people had remembered him for so long.

The First Sword of Zhongnan.

He was a Supreme Peak master produced by the Zhongnan Sect, a terrifying swordsman said to have mastered the ultimate principles of the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords.

There had to be great significance behind a figure comparable to the Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, personally stepping forward.

That was what Ju Hwaran found most puzzling.

"Why the Taeeul Merciless Sword, of all people?"

"He must be in a hurry. Zhongnan spent a fortune acquiring the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng because of the Roaring Fury Swordsman's Internal Injury, after all. His one and only Senior Brother ended up in that state. Imagine how he must feel."

On the surface, it sounded reasonable.

But Ju Hwaran clearly remembered what her father, Ju Hogun, had told her years ago.

He said the man was frightening.

Her father had been so benevolent that people called him the Junzi Sword.[1640] If even Ju Hogun, who judged others generously, had described him that way, then the Taeeul Merciless Sword had to be every bit as sharp as his swordsmanship.

I can't let my guard down until the very end.

After gathering her thoughts, Ju Hwaran asked Heo Jun about the one person still weighing on her mind.

"What about Captain Song?"

"Ah, about that…"

Heo Jun hesitated before answering.

"I had trustworthy escorts watching him discreetly day and night, but as you know, Hwaran, everyone let their guard down last night…"

"You took your eyes off him."

"I have no excuse. It was my fault for failing to keep a closer watch."

As Heo Jun awkwardly avoided her gaze, Ju Hwaran let out a small sigh.

"Haa…"

Song Ilseom, whose origins were unclear and whose reputation among the public was poor, had been one of their primary subjects of surveillance.

Her suspicions of him had grown particularly strong after he met Jin Taekyung.

[1640] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

I told him over and over to keep a close eye on Song Ilseom.

Heo Jun was certainly a good man. He had served the Yongbong Escort Bureau for more than thirty years and had been close enough to Ju Hogun for them to address each other as brothers.

But the careless side he occasionally showed, like now, had also led to mistakes both large and small.

All I can do is hope it doesn't happen this time.

The milk had already been spilled. In any case, the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng was in her possession.

Hiding her disappointment, Ju Hwaran spoke.

"Where did the Zhongnan Sect ask us to meet?"

"At a teahouse called Tengwang Pavilion on the western edge of Xi'an. They want us there by noon."

Tengwang Pavilion was a famous teahouse that Ju Hwaran had occasionally visited herself.

There would be plenty of witnesses, and the atmosphere was quiet, making it the perfect place to conclude an escort mission.

"We'll leave in fifteen minutes. Please prepare."

Baek Museong came to Xi'an Tower while we were in the middle of packing.

"Are you really leaving right away?"

"I'd like to stay a few more days too, but as you know, our schedule is a little tight."

"That's unfortunate. If possible, I would have liked to escort you to the main sect."

"I'll stop by on the way back. Give me a tour of Huashan then."

"Haha, don't worry. I'll take responsibility for showing you everything properly."

There it was again. The full-course promise.

Not that I was expecting the full course. I just hoped that when we met again, he wouldn't be busy beating the hell out of someone like he had been this time.

Then, as I stared at Baek Museong's face while he laughed heartily, a thought occurred to me.

Should I at least mention it? The Yongbong Escort Bureau and the Zhongnan Sect.

While I was debating, Baek Museong touched his face and asked,

"Why are you looking at me like that? Is there something on my face?"

"…"

"Young Hero Jin?"

"Oh, no. Something else just crossed my mind."

Shit, I don't know.

When you got right down to it, the Zhongnan Sect and the Yongbong Escort Bureau were both complete strangers to me. Whatever dispute they had was theirs to resolve.

I already had more than enough problems of my own. Worrying about this too would just be sticking my nose where it didn't belong.

This is the Murim, after all.

I muttered inwardly as I seated Jeok Cheongang on the pack frame. Then I picked up the furs and began piling them over him one by one.

Even as I worked, I couldn't understand why Ju Hwaran kept coming to mind.

Song Ilseom, whom I had only glimpsed in passing, came to mind along with her.

Now that I think about it, he was a suspicious bastard. He stank even worse than Gung Gibang.

After learning about the relationship between the Yongbong Escort Bureau and the Zhongnan Sect, I found myself wondering who that bastard really was.

His Level was a staggering 110. At that level, he could probably strip one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes clean to the bone.

He had looked to be in his early to mid-thirties at most, but… who was he, and which sect did he belong to?

Could he be an assassin sent by the Zhongnan Sect? No, that's probably going too far.

Had he simply fallen for Ju Hwaran's beauty and decided to stay?

No. If that were the case, there would have been no reason for him to hide his true abilities. Was this one of those stories where the protagonist hides his power? Did some loser hiding his power look cooler when he rescued her?

Ju Hwaran. We only exchanged a few words, but she seemed like a good person. She had a refreshingly direct way of speaking too.

She also possessed extraordinary martial talent, having reached the Peak realm at her age.

And then there was… right. The dimples that appeared when she smiled were pretty. So were her half-moon eyes.

Come to think of it, she looked like a cat.

Cats had always been my favorite animals.

"Um, Captain?"

"Hm? Yeah?"

I turned and saw Hyuk Mujin staring at me strangely.

And not just him. Gung Gibang, Cheongpung, and even Baek Museong were all looking at me the same way.

"What? Why is everyone staring at me?"

"Well, the thing is…"

Hyuk Mujin cautiously pointed at the pack frame.

“In my humble opinion, Great Hero Jeok is going to suffocate at this rate.”

“Gasp!”

I hurriedly flung aside the furs that had piled up like a mountain.

Jeok Cheongang, who had nearly gone to meet that person while still in a coma, was breathing faintly.

“Oh, Benefactor! You’re just like me!”

“Did you just insult me?”

“Ah. No, no. That isn’t what I meant…”

Ignoring Cheongpung as he instantly drooped, I began piling the furs back on. Jeok Cheongang’s slight frame quickly disappeared beneath them.

Only after making sure enough air could pass through did I hoist the pack frame onto my back.

“All right. If everyone’s ready, let’s get going.”

We stepped outside amid Xi’an Tower’s lavish hospitality.

The bustling streets of Xi’an were packed with people. Over the din, Baek Museong spoke.

“I’d like to see you off, but you won’t allow it, will you?”

“We’ll be seeing each other again later anyway.”

“Haha. I knew you’d say that. Then I’ll be off. Stay well, Martial Uncle Cheongpung.”

“Take care, Martial Nephew Baek!”

In the end, I hadn’t even brought it up.

Good. This was fine.

Just as I was about to turn away, alone in my lingering unease amid the warm farewells, I overheard someone speaking.

“Did you hear? The Taeeul Merciless Sword of the Zhongnan Sect is in Xi’an.”

“What? The Taeeul Merciless Sword? Why on earth would he come here?”

“How should I know? Someone saw him heading toward Tengwang Pavilion in the west. Apparently, he’s meeting with the Yongbong Escort Bureau… but I can’t say for sure.”

The whispering voices slowly faded into the distance.

I asked Cheongpung,

“Cheongpung.”

“Yes, Benefactor.”

“Have you ever had tea?”

“Yes! I have!”

“No, you haven’t tried tea yet.”

If I said you hadn’t, then you hadn’t.

Chapter 318

“Astringent.”

The old man muttered as he savored his Tieguanyin.[1641]

His broad shoulders belied his age, and his snow-white beard hung all the way to his navel, giving him the appearance of an immortal.

He would have looked the part, too, if not for the old sword propped beside him.

“I-I’m sorry, Senior. I haven’t reached my father’s level yet…”

“It’s a shame, but it can’t be helped. When the owner changes, it’s only natural for the tea to taste different. You may go.”

The teahouse owner, who had been bowing repeatedly, vanished as though he had been waiting for those very words.

The old man watched him leave, then ran a hand over his teacup.

“The three of us martial brothers used to stop by this place from time to time. That was more than thirty years ago. Your Master wasn’t the Sect Leader back then, either.”

“I see.”

Hyuk Sopyung answered from across the table.

He had kept his mouth shut for more than half an hour while the old man performed his tea ceremony, and his voice was cracked like a drought-stricken rice paddy.

“Would you like a cup?”

The old man’s gentle voice contained not the slightest hint of coercion.

But when the old man before him offered something, it had to be accepted. Hyuk Sopyung knew that, as did the thirty members of the Taeeul Sword Unit stationed throughout the teahouse.

“I would be honored, Senior Martial Uncle.”

The old man picked up the jade-colored teapot and tilted it over the empty cup Hyuk Sopyung held out respectfully.

Trickle.

The tea slowly began to fill the cup.

At the same time, Hyuk Sopyung’s expression changed drastically.

“…!”

“What is it?”

“I… It’s nothing.”

His words notwithstanding, Hyuk Sopyung was clearly struggling. His hand trembled, and his face flushed so red it seemed ready to burst.

[1641] Tieguanyin is a Chinese oolong tea named for Guanyin, a bodhisattva.

It was only tea, yet every drop that struck the cup bore down on him with terrifying pressure.

What the hell…?

It was an enormous amount of internal energy. An overwhelming force that even Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan Sect's greatest prodigy, could not withstand despite receiving every elixir available without restraint.

He drew up all the internal energy in his body and poured it into the teacup, but he reached his limit almost immediately.

Tap. Crack.

The instant the last drop fell, a hairline crack spread through the cup in Hyuk Sopyung's hand, and tea spilled over the rim.

That was when the old man's gaze darkened.

He was Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

"How old are you this year?"

"…I have reached thirty."

"When did you last see this old man?"

"Ten years ago."

"Yes, that's right. The Huashan–Zhongnan gathering. That was where we last met."

The Huashan–Zhongnan gathering. Or the Zhongnan–Huashan gathering.

Huashan and Zhongnan—the dragon and tiger crouched in Shaanxi Province—held a gathering once every ten years where their young prodigies competed against one another.

Its official purpose was to foster friendship and exchange through duels, but everyone knew it was really a competition between the two sects.

"I remember now. I watched with my own eyes as that bastard Baek Museong toyed with you."

"…!"

Hyuk Sopyung's eyelids trembled.

How could he forget? The defeat he had suffered that day. The merciless gaze of The First Sword of Zhongnan, who had sought him out the moment he returned to the main sect.

"At your age, this old man had already mastered eight-tenths of the Taeeul Divine Technique. What about you?"

"…I apologize."

"Ten years is enough time for mountains and rivers to change. Yet you remain exactly where you were."

The same goes for you, Senior Martial Uncle.

Hyuk Sopyung fought desperately to hold back the words rising in his throat.

Surely you haven't forgotten everything you did to me that day.

Talent without effort could never bloom.

Hyuk Sopyung loved martial arts. That was why he had been called the Zhongnan Sect's greatest prodigy. He had devoted himself to martial arts and swung his sword through blood and sweat.

But he had not slowly fallen apart simply because Huashan's Lone Crane, Baek Museong, defeated him in front of everyone.

"I already know you've been disgracing our sect's name. I hear you've made quite a name for yourself in Xi'an."

"Senior Martial Uncle…"

"This old man is speaking. Shut your mouth."

Hwangbo Eom's formerly dispassionate voice had turned colder than eternal ice.

"Watching all of you has been quite the farce. From top to bottom, every last one of you is splattering mud across the Zhongnan Sect's signboard."

By the top, he meant the Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il. By the bottom, he meant Hyuk Sopyung.

Even though his only Senior Brother was laid up with an Internal Injury, Hwangbo Eom continued to spew venom at him. Hyuk Sopyung and the disciples of the Taeeul Sword Unit realized once again that the merciless part of his epithet—

Taeeul Merciless Sword.

—did not apply only to his enemies.

"Your Master, who led the Zhongnan Sect into this sorry state, is just as pathetic. Why our Master ever handed the position of Sect Leader to someone like him…"

That was when Hyuk Sopyung's tightly pressed lips finally parted.

"You go too far."

"What did you say?"

Whoosh.

A gust swept over Hyuk Sopyung's entire body.

No—it was not wind.

It was a powerful wave of qi flowing from the Taeeul Merciless Sword, a Supreme Peak master produced by Zhongnan.

"I must be going deaf in my old age. Say that again."

But Hyuk Sopyung did not yield, even beneath the suffocating pressure.

"Your words… *ngh.* Go too far."

Though the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had never shown him warmth or affection, he was still Hyuk Sopyung's one and only Master. And more than that—

"He is the Sect Leader of the Great Zhongnan Sect. You are a Disciple of Zhongnan, just as this junior is. Show the Sect Leader the respect he is due."

"Respect for the Sect Leader?"

A sharp gleam flashed through Hwangbo Eom's eyes.

There had been a time when no one stood closer to the position of Zhongnan Sect Leader than he did.

He had a Senior Brother and Junior Brother under the same Master, but neither had been a true rival. Neither could match his martial prowess or his ruthlessness.

The Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect should have been Hwangbo Eom. It was only natural.

“And what could a nobody like you possibly know to dare…!”

Hwangbo Eom was about to roar when he abruptly closed his mouth.

He had noticed Hyuk Sopyung’s unwavering gaze. He had also sensed the strange current passing among the Zhongnan disciples of the Taeeul Sword Unit.

These bastards.

Hwangbo Eom’s gaze turned cold. At the same time, the powerful aura pouring from his body slowly subsided.

His lips moved beneath his snow-white beard.

“The Sect Leader of the Great Zhongnan Sect…”

Hwangbo Eom lifted his still more than half-full teacup and drained it. Deep furrows appeared between his wrinkled brows.

“Still astringent. With a new owner, neither the flavor nor the fragrance is what it used to be.”

“…!”

“The Great Zhongnan Sect? What a laughable thing to say. Zhongnan today is nothing more than a castle in the air. While you were lost in despair and wasting your days on drinking, women, and gambling, this old man was working to restore our sect.”

“What do you mean…?”

Confusion colored Hyuk Sopyung’s voice.

Hadn’t Hwangbo Eom shut himself away at the main sect? Even when his Senior Brother, the Roaring Fury Swordsman, returned with a serious Internal Injury, he had not shown his face even once.

Then how…?

Hyuk Sopyung’s thoughts were cut short when a group entered the teahouse.

At their head was a young woman whose mere presence seemed to brighten her surroundings.

“I am Ju Hwaran, Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau. I pay my respects to Great Hero Hwangbo, the Taeeul Merciless Sword.”

Ju Hwaran, the Dagger Hidden Flower.

At her bold greeting, the corners of Hwangbo Eom’s mouth curled upward.

“Good. Did you bring the item I requested?”

He stroked his thick beard, his eyes flashing with an unreadable light.

“By the way, who’s the Taeeul Merciless Sword?”

Speed Beggar answered gruffly.

“Who else would the Taeeul Merciless Sword be? He’s the Taeeul Merciless Sword.”

“Gibang. Aren’t you curious which is stronger—the Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms at five-tenths power or the Flame Divine Palm at seven-tenths?”

“…The Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom. He’s the Junior Brother of the Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il, and the Senior Brother of the current Zhongnan Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord.”

As expected of a walking encyclopedia of the Murim. I hadn’t brought him along for moments like this, but he was useful in all sorts of ways.

Except for the smell.

I muttered inwardly as I kept walking.

We were on our way to a teahouse called Tengwang Pavilion. Gung Gibang walked beside me, looking deeply displeased.

“I’ve been thinking about this, and I don’t think it’s a good idea.”

“Why?”

“This is bigger than I expected. And it isn’t just anyone—it’s the Taeeul Merciless Sword. At least you can reason with the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, but that man…”

Gung Gibang couldn’t finish his sentence and shook his head repeatedly.

“Why? How bad is he? Have you met him before?”

“Once, while I was with my Master. That was enough to make me never want to see him again.”

Judging by Gung Gibang’s reaction, Hwangbo Eom must have made one hell of a first impression.

He shuddered with a disgusted expression, then gave me a sidelong glance.

“You don’t need to ask me. No one knows a household better than its neighbor.”

At the end of Gung Gibang’s gaze was Baek Museong, who had been walking silently without saying a word.

The face that usually wore a relaxed smile had long since hardened like stone.

Okay. I get the picture.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword.

As you spent time in the Murim, you started noticing a few interesting things. One of them was martial epithets.

An epithet contained a piece of the person it belonged to. Sometimes it told you what weapon they favored. Other times, it revealed their personality.

In Hwangbo Eom's case, it did both.

Merciless. That word alone tells me more or less what I need to know.

I'd bet Hyuk Mujin's wrist that he wasn't some genial neighborhood grandpa who chuckled all day. If that wasn't enough, I'd throw in his ankle too.

Gung Gibang spoke anxiously.

"It's not too late to turn back."

"Hm? Turn back from what?"

"Interfering in matters between sects is likely to cause trouble. Even more so when the other party is the Taeeul Merciless Sword of the Zhongnan Sect."

"So?"

"What do you mean, 'so'? I'm telling you to forget this nonsense and go to Sichuan!"

I blinked innocently.

"What the hell are you talking about?"

"Huh?"

"Who's interfering? We're just going to drink some tea. Isn't that right, Cheongpung?"

Cheongpung, who was chewing the candied sweets I had bought to keep him quiet, answered enthusiastically.

"Yes! We're going to drink tea!"

Gung Gibang stared at him incredulously.

"Didn't you say earlier that you'd already had tea?"

"Uh… Well…"

No wonder his answer had sounded so evasive.

Cheongpung had already polished off the sweets in the blink of an eye. He sucked on his fingers and looked back and forth between Gung Gibang and me.

His eyes dripped with longing as they swept across a street stall overflowing with snacks.

"Cheongpung, you've never had tea before. Right?"

As I spoke, I spread one hand wide and waved it over Gung Gibang's shoulder. Five more candied sweets were added to Cheongpung's share, and he nodded eagerly.

"That's right! I've never had tea before! My butt's itching to get to the teahouse!"

"You heard him."

His will to fight shattered, Gung Gibang tore at his matted hair.

"Damn it. If Master beats me with the Dog-Beating Staff[1642] later, I'm telling him this was all your fault."

"Go ahead. My Master is the Fire King."

[1642] The Dog-Beating Staff is a signature weapon of the Beggars' Sect.

“You miserable bastard. You’re worse than a dog.”

“Stop whining and keep walking. What about you, Mujin? Got a problem?”

Hyuk Mujin looked at me hopefully.

“Am I allowed to say so?”

“Sure. If you want to die.”

“…”

“All right. We’re almost there.”

The weathered signboard bearing the name Tengwang Pavilion drew steadily closer.

I strode onward until I finally stopped before the teahouse door.

Well, this is no joke.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword. The greatest swordsman Zhongnan could boast of. I could feel the aura of a Supreme Peak master beyond the door, along with the presence of dozens of people carrying considerable qi.

The pack frame on my shoulders suddenly felt heavier.

“Old Master, don’t worry. No matter what happens, I’ll protect you.”

“Nothing will happen,” I muttered softly, then threw open the door.

Chapter 319

“I am Ju Hwaran, Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau. I pay my respects to Great Hero Hwangbo, the Taeeul Merciless Sword.”

Ju Hwaran gave a crisp, formal clasped-hands salute.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom, truly lived up to his reputation. Merely meeting his gaze made her chest tighten and left her struggling to breathe.

The First Sword of Zhongnan…

The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families—the fifteen pillars supporting the Murim of today.

The man before her was the greatest master of the Zhongnan Sect, one of those fifteen powers. The immense weight of his name pressed down on her.

But it’s all right.

She had completed an escort mission everyone had agreed was impossible.

That was why she could stand tall even if the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord himself had come instead of the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

“Well? Did you bring the item I requested?”

“Of course.”

As she answered, Ju Hwaran took the wooden casket containing the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng from inside her robes. Straw rope was wound tightly around the entire casket, and a few small words had been written on its knot.

Shandong Seongsu Jang Family.

Hwangbo Eom checked the writing and nodded.

“No mistake. It bears the seal of the Seongsu Jang Family.”

People said that if Sichuan had the Tang Family, then Shandong had the Seongsu Jang Family.

That was how renowned the Seongsu Jang Family was for its medical arts. Unlike the Sichuan Tang Clan, a Murim great family, it was a prestigious medical family with its roots in medicine.

The Zhongnan Sect had purchased the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng through that very family and entrusted its transportation to the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

“The Pill Physician, the current Family Head of the Seongsu Jang Family, personally placed the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng inside and signed the casket.”

“Oh? The Pill Physician himself?”

“Yes. Several witnesses, myself included, watched the entire process.”

“You’re remarkably thorough for someone your age.”

Hwangbo Eom stroked his white beard with wrinkled fingers.

"This old man has heard that the Junzi Sword's[1643] daughter is a gifted young woman. Thank you for handling such a difficult assignment so reliably."

"Our Yongbong Escort Bureau does not tolerate even the slightest mistake on an escort mission."

"That must be why you're called the best in Shaanxi. Our sect operates an Escort Bureau as well, but it cannot compare with yours. Ha ha ha."

Ju Hwaran's heart pounded.

Was it because Hwangbo Eom had praised her?

No. It had nothing to do with his praise. Something else was constricting her chest, and she knew the name of that feeling.

Anxiety.

Something is wrong.

It was an intuition bordering on foresight. But before Ju Hwaran could even begin to trace its source, Hwangbo Eom spoke.

"Well, only the final procedure remains."

They would inspect the requested item, then each leave their signature to certify that the handover was complete.

After a simple procedure that would take less than the time needed to drink a cup of tea, the four-month escort mission that had cost them so dearly would finally come to an end.

That was how it was supposed to happen.

...But would it really?

A chill unlike anything she had ever felt crept up her spine.

Hwangbo Eom's voice pierced her frozen ears.

"What are you waiting for? Show me the item."

Ju Hwaran slowly raised her head.

His voice was kind and gentle, yet the old man's pitch-black eyes gleamed with a strange light.

She barely managed to force the words past her red lips.

"...Great Hero Hwangbo."

"Open the casket. With your own hands."

Ju Hwaran realized it then—the source of her anxiety, and that she had nowhere left to retreat.

In the end, only one choice remained.

Rustle.

[1643] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

Her slender, trembling fingers began to untie the knot. The wooden casket she had kept close to her heart for the past four months suddenly felt alien, as though she were seeing it for the first time.

No. No, that can't be. I'm certain. There's no way…

And then—

Click.

At last, the wooden casket opened, revealing what lay inside. A pure fragrance, straight roots, and a frost-covered, snow-white body.

It was unmistakably snow ginseng. Yet everyone who saw it held their breath, their eyes widening.

Hwangbo Eom's gentle voice rang through the suffocating silence.

"How amusing."

He crooked one wrinkled finger, releasing a powerful stream of internal energy.

The snow ginseng floated into the air through Seizing an Object Through Empty Space as he continued.

"A Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng… Is this old man seeing things because his strength has waned?"

It was obvious who the question was meant for.

Every gaze turned in the same direction. The horrified Chief Escort Heo Jun and Song Ilseom, who had been standing at a slant as though he weren't there, were no exception.

At the end of those dozens of gazes stood Ju Hwaran, her face pale and her eyes closed.

It's over.

The moment she saw the Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng inside the casket, she had shut her eyes, unable to face the sight.

Something that could not and should not have happened had happened.

I saw it myself. I even kept it in my possession.

Where had everything gone wrong?

The past few months flashed through the darkness before her eyes like scenes from a dream.

She had staked the Yongbong Escort Bureau's very survival on this mission.

The Zhongnan Sect had offered an enormous sum for completing it. But if they failed, the Bureau would have to pay ten times that amount as a penalty.

And now that double-edged sword had plunged into the hearts of both Ju Hwaran and the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

"I won't ask how this happened. I have no interest in whatever extraordinary circumstances caused the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng to turn into a Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng. However…"

Hwangbo Eom swept a look of feigned regret over Ju Hwaran and the other members of the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

"We will have to receive compensation for this matter."

"…!"

"Our sect has already paid the Seongsu Jang Family one hundred thousand silver nyang[1644] for the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng. And if the Yongbong Escort Bureau successfully completed the mission, we agreed to pay an escort fee of ten thousand silver nyang[1645]—one-tenth of the cargo's value."

The value of the lost Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, plus the tenfold penalty the Yongbong Escort Bureau owed for failing to fulfill the contract.

Together, they amounted to the astronomical sum of two hundred thousand silver nyang[1646]. It was an amount they could cover only by selling off most of what the Yongbong Escort Bureau owned.

Blood ran from Ju Hwaran's lips as the realization struck her, and Chief Escort Heo Jun's face went black.

"G-Great Hero Hwangbo, that is…!"

"Two hundred thousand silver nyang[1647]. I will permit no compromise."

"A-Ah…"

The escorts who had accompanied Ju Hwaran groaned in despair.

Every one of them except Song Ilseom.

Though the Escort Bureau where he had worked for nearly ten years now faced a desperate crisis, he showed no reaction. Only the corner of his mouth twitched once.

Hwangbo Eom caught the movement out of the corner of his eye, then held out a full cup of tea to Ju Hwaran.

"Have a cup. When the mind is troubled, nothing is better than a warm cup of tea."

Ju Hwaran's long, tightly shut eyelashes trembled. Slowly, she opened her eyes and stared at Hwangbo Eom.

"Is this… Is this Zhongnan's way?"

"I'm afraid I don't know what you mean."

Hwangbo Eom laughed softly and raised his own teacup to his lips.

As expected, the tea was astringent. The young owner who had inherited the teahouse from his family was still inexperienced.

And yet, for some reason, the aroma and flavor lingering in Hwangbo Eom's mouth now were incomparable to what he had tasted a moment ago.

[1644] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won.
[1645] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won.
[1646] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won.
[1647] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won.

"Very good. I feel as though I've gone back thirty years."

"…!"

"What's wrong? Drink before it gets cold."

Ju Hwaran silently bit her lip.

She had been completely outmaneuvered. Even after taking every precaution, she had still fallen into the trap.

For the past two years, she had led the Escort Bureau in place of her father, the Junzi Sword,[1648] Ju Hogun. She had endured all kinds of mistakes and failures, both large and small, but never had she faced anything as hopeless as this.

Can I rise again like before?

She had stumbled before, but she had never stayed down. Yet two hundred thousand silver nyang[1649] was enough to crush the Yongbong Escort Bureau out of existence.

We can pay the penalty.

It was possible.

They would have to sell every field and parcel of land owned by the Yongbong Escort Bureau for a pittance, then send away the hundreds of caravan porters, escorts, and Escort Captains whose wages they could no longer afford.

And once that entire process was over, nothing would remain of the Yongbong Escort Bureau but an empty shell.

Is it really over? Just like this?

Hwangbo Eom watched Ju Hwaran with amusement.

He had long heard that the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau was quite capable.

But to him, she was still nothing more than a naive greenhorn.

Heh. How pitiful.

Just as Hwangbo Eom chuckled inwardly—

"Hmm?"

His gaze suddenly turned toward the door of the teahouse. Several people's qi was drawing closer.

This is…

The qi was so powerful that even Hwangbo Eom, a Supreme Peak master, could not easily ignore it.

A vast reserve of internal energy comparable to that of an Elder from the Nine Sects and One Gang steadily approached, then stopped directly outside the teahouse.

Could it be Huashan?

[1648] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

[1649] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency, not modern Korean won.

Hwangbo Eom's prediction was proven spectacularly wrong the next moment.

Creaaak.

"Oh, I was just in the mood for some tea, and look at that! A teahouse, right when I needed one."

A broad-shouldered young man opened the door and strode in at the head of the group.

Hwangbo Eom's eyes darkened as he looked at Jin Taekyung.

Even at a glance, it was an unusual sight.

Dozens of swordsmen stood throughout the room, and the air hung heavy.

Ju Hwaran—or rather, the Yongbong Escort Bureau?

The question had barely crossed my mind when I spotted them.

On top of a table surrounded by people, slender fingers trembled faintly.

I had only met her once, but I could tell who she was just from her fingers. Funny how that worked.

Were her hands pretty?

As I scratched the back of my head, everyone's gaze flew toward me.

A middle-aged man who appeared to be the owner of the teahouse hurried over, bowing repeatedly.

"Sir, I'm sorry, but we're completely full right now…"

"There's a seat over there."

"That seat isn't in use."

"Then I'll drink standing up."

At that moment, a martial artist who appeared to be a Disciple of the Zhongnan Sect approached with measured steps.

"Are you a martial artist?"

"No, I'm fat."

The martial artist looked me up and down as if he were staring at a complete lunatic.

"I don't know who you are or where you come from, but an important person is here right now. You would do well to leave."

"I'm an important son in my own family too, so why should I? There's plenty of room anyway."

"…You're being troublesome. I am a Disciple of the Great Zhongnan Sect. You should understand by now, so leave."

"Why do you keep ordering me around? I just want to sit down and have some tea."

Cheongpung, who had been fidgeting behind me, shouted excitedly.

“Benefactor! Candied sweets too!”

“Candied sweets? Hey, Mujin. Does this teahouse sell those too?”

“Are you seriously saying that right now?”

The Zhongnan Sect disciple looked at us as if to say, *What the hell is wrong with these guys?* Then he spotted someone, and his face stiffened.

“H-Huashan’s Lone Crane, Baek Museong!”

Maybe it was because this was Huashan’s home ground, but quite a few people here recognized Baek Museong.

In any case, the Zhongnan Disciple’s involuntary shout had an immediate effect. Unlike when we first entered, everyone was looking at us now.

Two gazes stood out from the rest.

I waved at one of them.

“Oh, we meet again.”

“…Young Hero Jin?”

Ju Hwaran stared at me with her pale face and wide, round eyes.

Across from her sat an old man with a long white beard.

I gave Ju Hwaran a small smile, then gazed at the old man.

“Is there some problem between you and Young Lady Ju?”

The old man—the Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom—stroked his beard and laughed.

“An interesting fellow has appeared.”

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The old man had the bearing of an immortal. I had heard he was nearly eighty, yet as befitted a Supreme Peak master with profound internal energy, his clear, refined face bore not a single age spot, and his back was perfectly straight.

And then there were his eyes.

Their dark gleam was enough to make anyone uncomfortable the moment they met his gaze. The old man—the Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom—spoke.

“An interesting fellow has appeared.”

I met his stare and answered.

“I hear that pretty often.”

“You have plenty of nerve too.”

“That’s also true.”

The corners of Hwangbo Eom’s mouth rose.

“You must know who this old man is. Enough of your pointless wordplay.”

“Who are you?”

“What?”

“We’ve never met before. How am I supposed to know who you are or where you’re from? You have to introduce yourself. That’s basic etiquette.”

Startled gasps came from all around at my nonchalant reply.

“Y-Young Hero Jin.”

Ju Hwaran and the others from the Yongbong Escort Bureau gaped at me, while the Zhongnan Sect disciples, realizing what was happening, reached for their sword hilts as one.

“How dare you behave so insolently!”

“Show some respect at once!”

Hwangbo Eom raised a hand and calmed them.

Normally, this was the point when someone would start foaming at the mouth and check their blood pressure as it shot through the roof.

But Hwangbo Eom was clearly different.

“So that’s how it is.”

He studied me with a faint smile, then slowly turned his head.

His gaze passed over me, Cheongpung, and Hyuk Mujin before settling on the other two.

“You do not know this old man? The pillar of Huashan and the Successor Beggar of the Beggars’ Sect must have told you already. A joke carried too far becomes unpleasant.”

Baek Museong and Gung Gibang flinched, then stepped forward and offered clasped-hands salutes.

“I am Baek Museong, a humble junior of the Murim. I pay my respects to Great Hero Hwangbo.”

“I-I am Gung Gibang of the Beggars’ Sect…”

“Enough.”

Hwangbo Eom waved them off, his robe sleeve fluttering, and turned his gaze back to me.

“I believe I have indulged a child’s tantrum long enough. Is that still not enough for you?”

He really was no ordinary old man.

He was a completely different breed from his Senior Brother, the Roaring Fury Swordsman.

Both his martial arts and his temperament were a cut above.

He’s a tricky one.

Still, this was more or less what I had expected.

Without letting my thoughts show, I shrugged calmly.

“No, that’s enough. Great Hero Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword.”

“You’re certainly bold. Why not claim you failed to recognize me?”

“Because it looks better to admit it cleanly.”

“Hahaha! What an insolent brat.”

Hwangbo Eom burst into hearty laughter. He sounded both intrigued by me and utterly dumbfounded.

The Zhongnan Sect disciples under his command, however, seemed to find the situation not merely absurd but insulting.

It would have been one thing if I genuinely had not known who he was.

But I had known and only pretended otherwise.

Hwangbo Eom’s standing within the Zhongnan Sect must have been too high for them to simply laugh it off.

“You bastard!”

Was it called the Taeeul Sword Unit?

It started when a middle-aged man who appeared to be the eldest of the Zhongnan Sect disciples shouted and drew his sword.

Clang-clang-clang!

Thirty well-maintained swords pointed toward me. As disciples of the Zhongnan Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, every one of them was at least a First Rate master.

Of course…

They’re hopelessly weak.

At this level, they posed no threat to me whatsoever.

First Rate? Peak? It made no difference.

In my eyes, they were nothing more than thirty men with swords.

I am strong.

Might Makes Right.

One of the absolute laws governing the Murim.

Before I knew it, I had become strong enough to remain at ease under that law. That was why I could stride forward without hesitation.

"Since fate brought us together, would you mind if I joined you?"

I addressed Hwangbo Eom, ignoring the thirty blades surrounding me. The middle-aged swordsman leading them flushed red.

"H-How dare you, you insolent bastard!"

"*Bangjajeon*[1650] is so damn good."

"Taeeul Sword Unit, hear my command! Seize this bastard—"

That was when Hwangbo Eom, who had been silently watching me, finally spoke.

"Join us… Very well."

"…!"

Everyone stared at him in surprise.

"S-Senior Martial Uncle?"

"Put away your swords."

"B-But that bastard—"

"Do you intend to defy this old man's command?"

At his icy voice, the middle-aged swordsman bit his lip and lowered his sword.

As the weapons that had brightly illuminated the inside of the teahouse disappeared, nothing remained to block my way.

"Thank you. All that glare was getting hard on the eyes."

Scrape. Thump.

I passed the people standing rigid with shock and dropped into the seat beside Ju Hwaran. Seeing how pale she was, I gave her a slight smile.

"Long time no—well, not really. It's been two days. How have you been?"

"Young Hero Jin…"

"You don't have to answer. I was only being polite. Honestly, Young Lady Ju, judging by your expression, you don't look like you've been doing very well."

"That's not what I meant. How did you even—?"

"I happened to be passing by and stopped in by chance. Cheongpung here insisted on having a cup of tea. Of course, that was also a coincidence."

[1650] *Bangjajeon* (*The Servant*) is a Korean film title that echoes the word just used for "insolent."

Unlike Baek Museong, Gung Gibang, and Hyuk Mujin, Cheongpung—whose duodenum was apparently made entirely of liver[1651]—sat down beside me without hesitation and pouted.

“Benefactor, when are the candied sweets coming?”

“Wait just a little longer. I’ll pile them into a whole mountain for you.”

“Wow! A mountain of sweets!”

Cheongpung looked ecstatic, as though a mountain of candied sweets had appeared right before his eyes.

Ju Hwaran, on the other hand, looked as though a mountain had collapsed on top of her.

Of course, most of that was probably because of Hwangbo Eom sitting across from her.

He looked back and forth between Cheongpung and me with an odd gleam in his eyes, then spoke.

“You have quite the nerve. Almost recklessly so.”

“It used to be small. But after going through one thing and another, it suddenly grew a lot.”

“This and that, you say. I suppose the Shaolin Bloodshed would do that.”

“…!”

“Why so surprised?”

Hwangbo Eom curled his lips into a smile and continued.

“I have heard all about the rumor that the Fire King took a Hidden Dragon under his wing. I also heard that you left the Murim Alliance seven days and nights ago.”

What a slippery old man.

He had known from the start.

Unlike Ju Hwaran, who had merely guessed our identities two days ago, he already knew everything.

How?

This operation had been carried out quickly and in secret, yet he knew everything as if he could see the palm of his hand.

Did the Zhongnan Sect Leader, who should still be at the Murim Alliance, send a messenger pigeon?

Then could he also know about Old Master’s condition…?

Just as the thought crossed my mind, Hwangbo Eom’s gaze flicked toward the pack frame I had entrusted to Baek Museong before sitting down.

Then he casually tossed out a remark.

[1651] In Korean, the liver is associated with courage; having a large liver means being bold. The image exaggerates Cheongpung’s fearlessness.

“Though I never expected the Fire King’s heir to be dressed like a leather merchant.”

Was he pretending not to know, or did he genuinely have no idea?

His expression gave nothing away.

Jeok Cheongang was currently in a state resembling suspended animation. His heartbeat, breathing, and every other bodily function had slowed to the extreme, making his presence extraordinarily difficult to detect.

It was similar to the Turtle Breath Technique Cheongpung had mentioned before.

And with all those hides piled over him, even a Supreme Peak master would have trouble noticing him.

Keeping him warm was not the only reason we had covered him with so many hides.

They concealed his appearance, muffled every sound, and hid his presence so no one would discover he was there.

“…”

“What is it?”

“Nothing. Anyway, I’m thirsty.”

I hurriedly redirected Hwangbo Eom’s attention. Without another word, he picked up the teapot and held a cup out to me.

“Take it.”

“Don’t mind if I do.”

Pour.

Hwangbo Eom was no pushover.

I felt the profound internal energy carried through the stream of tea and clicked my tongue inwardly.

So this is Zhongnan’s greatest master.

The tea fell in a slow, graceful arc, yet the force within it was heavy and powerful enough to shatter a boulder.

Still, it’s not as strong as Old Master’s.

Jeok Cheongang had a mischievous streak and had played all sorts of tricks on me. What Hwangbo Eom was doing now was no different.

I had broken more than one or two cups this way.

Besides, Jeok Cheongang stood foremost among the Ten Kings, an absolute master sometimes compared even to the Three Saints.

This much is nothing.

When I did not so much as blink, Hwangbo Eom’s eyebrow twitched. At the same time, the internal energy carried by the tea grew even stronger.

“Great Hero Hwangbo.”

“Hm?”

"The tea's about to overflow."

"…"

"You can stop pouring now."

Just as I had said, the cup was already full. I lifted the perfectly smooth cup, not a single hairline crack on its surface, and emptied it in one gulp.

"Ahh. That hit the spot."

"You seem fond of tea."

"Not really. Anyway, allow me to pour you a cup this time."

I reached out, and the teapot glided through the air into my hand.

It was the art martial artists called Seizing an Object Through Empty Space.

I possessed nearly two jiazi's[1652] worth of internal energy and insight that had reached the brink of the Peak realm. I did not use the technique often because it consumed so much internal energy, but I could perform it whenever I wished.

I need to put on at least this much of a show.

Old Master had once said in passing:

"There are idiots everywhere in the Murim. You have to show those bastards something flashy before they'll listen. Look at this old man. All I did was beat the Demonic Cult bastards because they pissed me off, and they still call me a king."

King Cheongang indeed. Spoken like a man who had turned the Murim upside down by racking up a thousand kills all by himself.

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space isn't quite on that level, but it's still an impressive technique.

Sure enough, the onlookers' eyes widened.

"He used Seizing an Object Through Empty Space so easily…"

"Good heavens."

Few people could use Seizing an Object Through Empty Space as casually as I had. Especially at my age.

But I did not stop there. I drew up my internal energy.

I circulated the Fire Gate Divine Technique to seven-tenths, and Extreme Yang energy seeped into both my hands.

Fwoosh!

Heat burst forth, and the tea inside the pot began to boil violently. I calmly filled Hwangbo Eom's cup and said,

"The tea had gone a little cold. Since you're going to drink it anyway, wouldn't it be better warm? The weather has been cold lately, and the older you get, the more careful you have to be."

"…!"

[1652] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar. Nearly two jiazi's worth of internal energy means nearly 120 years' worth.

Hwangbo Eom’s face stiffened.

Heating tea with internal energy would not have been particularly difficult for him either. There was a technique called Samadhi True Fire, after all.

But the Fire Gate Divine Technique was renowned as the greatest divine technique under heaven when it came to controlling Scorching Yang Qi.

No matter how powerful a Supreme Peak master Hwangbo Eom was, he could not match the Fire Gate Divine Technique.

And… No. It was too soon to jump to that conclusion.

I cut off the thought before it could go any further and offered him the cup.

“Please, drink.”

“Ahem.”

“Here comes the tea! Chug, chug, chug-chug!”

“…I shall drink it properly.”

“Look at my internal organs! I’ve suffered internal injuries!”

“…”

Hwangbo Eom glared at me, then drained the cup.

When he set it down, his gaze had changed considerably from when he had regarded me as a mere youngster.

“Your martial arts are quite impressive.”

I smiled and waved a hand.

“Oh, no. Not at all.”

“Do you intend to deceive this old man’s eyes?”

“No. I meant my martial arts aren’t merely ‘quite impressive.‘ They’re extremely impressive.”

“Your arrogance knows no—”

“Oh, and for the record, my Master said that. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. You know him, right?”

Now I was the only one smiling.

Not a trace of amusement remained on Hwangbo Eom’s face.

After a brief silence, he abruptly asked,

“What are you plotting?”

“Pardon?”

“Your insolence reaches the heavens. I have heard enough nonsense about this being a coincidence. Tell me the truth.”

“You’re refreshingly direct. In that case, sure.”

A faint smile touched my lips as I continued.

“I was just passing by when I happened to wonder what kind of dirty trick the Zhongnan Sect was trying to pull, so I came to take a look.”

At those words, the eyes of Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword, turned cold.

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“What… did you just say?”

Hwangbo Eom’s voice was stretched so taut it seemed ready to snap.

The snow-white beard that had made him look like an immortal bristled, and his eyes hardened as he stared at me.

I answered with a mild smile.

“Didn’t I just tell you? I came to see what kind of dirty trick you were pulling. By. Chance.”

At that moment, blue sparks flew from Hwangbo Eom’s eyes.

“Hah!”

With his thunderous roar, an immense wave of qi erupted from him.

The aura of a Supreme Peak master made the table—or rather, the ground itself—pitch like a ship caught in a storm.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The violent tremors threw the entire teahouse into chaos. Dozens of pieces of teaware shattered with a deafening crash, spraying tea in every direction.

The proprietor, who had been nervously watching from a corner, let out a shriek and collapsed to the floor.

I instantly raised my sleeve to shield Ju Hwaran’s face from the flying tea, then clicked my tongue.

“Someone your age shouldn’t be causing a scene in another person’s shop. Not with other people around.”

“How dare you…”

The pressure radiating from Hwangbo Eom intensified.

This was the aura of none other than The First Sword of Zhongnan. Even the swordsmen of the Taeeul Sword Unit arrayed around him like guards flinched as though burned and stumbled backward. The members of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, Ju Hwaran included, went deathly pale.

“Hngh!”

“Gasp!”

No matter how talented a young prodigy might be, the gulf between them and Hwangbo Eom was as vast as the distance between heaven and earth.

Baek Museong, known as a pillar of Huashan, and Gung Gibang, Successor Beggar of the Beggars’ Sect and its hundred thousand members, fared little better than Ju Hwaran.

Even counting everyone present, only about three people still looked unaffected.

One was me, of course.

“Benefactor, when are the candied sweets coming out?”

Another was Cheongpung, who cared only about his candied sweets, to hell with the Taeeul Merciless Sword or anything else.

And the last was…

"Hmm."

Song Ilseom, the fierce-eyed escort.

He gave a quiet grunt under the weight of Hwangbo Eom's aura. When our eyes met, he frowned and turned away.

I don't like you either, asshole.

From the moment I first saw him, Song Ilseom had stunk of something suspicious in more ways than one.

It would not take long to find out whether that impression of mine was mistaken or based on fact.

"Maybe it's because no one opened a window, but the air feels awfully stuffy."

I spoke calmly and drew up my internal energy. The hundred years of internal energy coiled within my dantian spread between the tables like an invisible curtain.

Freed from the crushing pressure, Ju Hwaran finally released the breath she had been holding.

"Young Lady Ju, are you all right?"

"Yes, yes."

Still gasping, Ju Hwaran clutched my sleeve.

"Thank you, Young Hero Jin. But this…"

"Enough."

A single word from Hwangbo Eom cut her off.

The immortal had transformed into a Fiend. He glared at me, his gaze brimming with killing intent.

"The arrogance of a young whelp like you pierces the heavens."

"I'm pretty good at piercing things. I use a spear."

"Do you even understand what you're doing?"

"Of course."

I leaned lazily against the hard back of my chair and continued.

"I'm rescuing innocent people who fell into a trap someone laid for them. Purely because I happened to be passing by, of course."

"A trap. I presume that 'someone' refers to our sect."

"Well, you're free to think whatever you like."

The fury in Hwangbo Eom's eyes subsided. In its place, an unmistakable sneer spread across his lips.

"You seem unaware that a man must answer for his words."

"Judging by the fact that I came here, I'd say I'm well aware of that."

"Boy, you have insulted the Great Zhongnan Sect with baseless accusations you cannot prove. Do you wish to make us your enemy?"

"It's funny to hear orthodox Murim companions talk about friend and foe. Are you perhaps from an unorthodox faction?"

"You insolent whelp!"

"I already heard what happened between the Yongbong Escort Bureau and your sect. That's why I came."

I picked up the snow ginseng rolling across the table.

The thing in my hand was certainly an excellent elixir. Yet the name displayed through Item Appraisal had not changed.

Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng.

I already knew that the item Zhongnan Sect had commissioned the Yongbong Escort Bureau to transport was Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng.

It was a peerless elixir said to grant a full jiazi[1653] of internal energy instantly upon consumption.

Murim practitioners would risk their lives to possess such a rare treasure, and its value was whatever price the seller cared to name.

According to the information Gung Gibang had gathered, the Yongbong Escort Bureau had staked its survival on this escort mission.

Unless Ju Hwaran was a complete fool, there was no way she would have thrown such precious cargo into a wagon and left it unattended.

Then where had the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng gone? And why had it been replaced with Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng, an elixir far inferior to it?

It was obvious.

It could only mean that either the Zhongnan Sect or Hwangbo Eom personally had meddled with it.

On top of that, the Zhongnan Sect had been deeply involved in the Yongbong Escort Bureau's decline for the past two years.

The Xi'an branch of the Beggars' Sect, whose information network was said to rival the Lower District Sect's for the finest under heaven, had already pieced together most of what had happened.

This was supposed to be the finishing blow.

The Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng was the final strike meant to bring down the cornered Yongbong Escort Bureau.

They had dangled bait too tempting to resist, then dug an inescapable trap beneath it. The result was unfolding before my eyes.

But…

[1653] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; here, it denotes sixty years' worth of internal energy.

“You know, living in this world has taught me something. Even when everything looks finished, something unexpected can suddenly pop up and throw the whole thing into disarray.”

Hwangbo Eom regarded my muttering with contempt.

“A brat who still reeks of his mother’s milk does nothing but wag his tongue. Has becoming the Fire King’s Disciple blinded you to your place, you country bumpkin from Shanxi?”

“I’m still young, so there’s no need to worry about my eyesight. You’re the one who should be concerned about failing vision, Great Hero Hwangbo.”

“How should I tear apart that wicked mouth of yours?”

“I don’t know whether my mouth is wicked, but I do know Zhongnan’s specialty. You can’t utter a word when someone stronger than you shows up. Was it a year ago? Your Senior Brother gave me an advance lesson.”

I still remembered it clearly.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman had invoked Zhongnan’s name to pressure the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I even remembered the sight of him being driven away without managing a single proper word after the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, appeared.

I pressed my lips together and looked at Hyuk Sopyung, who sat beside Hwangbo Eom.

“And yesterday, I had a review session.”

Hwangbo Eom was a perceptive old man.

Realizing what had happened, he clicked his tongue and muttered, “…Our sect is crawling with worms.”

“Still, aren’t harmful pests better than venomous insects? From my point of view, getting drunk and causing a scene is much more exemplary than ruining a perfectly good escort bureau.”

“You dare call this old man venomous? Hah. Hahaha!”

Contrary to my expectations, I could no longer sense the slightest agitation from Hwangbo Eom.

He looked down on everyone present, myself included, like a hawk high above that was ready to swoop down and seize its prey.

“Boy, do you understand what it means to make an enemy of the Great Zhongnan Sect—and of this old man?”

His wrinkled hand pressed against the table. The spilled tea slowly rose, took the form of an arrow, and pointed straight between my brows.

“If this old man so much as wishes it, today will be the day of your funeral.”

That’s what you think.

I opened my mouth.

"Well, from either your perspective or mine, that doesn't sound like a particularly good choice."

"That is why you remain alive. This old man will personally punish you for today's offense in due time. If you do not wish to die like a dog, withdraw. This is a matter between our sect and the Yongbong Escort Bureau."

Just as I was about to respond, a hand tugged at my sleeve.

At the same time, a trembling woman's voice, carried on internal energy, pierced my ears.

—*Young Hero Jin…*

Two days ago, Ju Hwaran's eyes had been clear and spotless. Now they swirled with conflicting emotions.

Fear and anger at what was happening. Relief at my arrival, and worry for my safety.

I knew exactly what she was thinking and what she wanted to say.

—*I'm grateful that you're thinking of us, but he's right. This is an affair between the Yongbong Escort Bureau and the Zhongnan Sect. If you get involved any further, you'll put yourself in danger as well.*

Looking into Ju Hwaran's eyes suddenly brought back a memory from a year ago.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman had threatened to seal the gates of the Jin Family of Taiyuan for an absurd reason. What would have happened that day if Jeok Cheongang had not appeared?

Orthodox faction? What a load of fucking bullshit.

The righteousness of the powerful was not the same as the righteousness of the weak.

I did not believe everyone in the orthodox Murim was evil. At the same time, I did not believe they were all good.

Even Shaolin Temple surely had people with wicked hearts, and I believed there were good people even within the Demonic Cult, that supposed den of fiends and monsters.

Orthodox, unorthodox, demonic. Good and evil existed in all three.

It isn't about the sect. It's about the person.

In the end, the individual was what mattered. And the old man before me was one of the biggest fucking bastards under heaven.

I took a deep breath, then spoke to Ju Hwaran aloud rather than using Sound Transmission.

"Young Lady Ju."

"Y-Young Hero Jin?"

"You're right. This is an affair between the Zhongnan Sect and the Yongbong Escort Bureau. If I stick my nose into it, all I'll get is a loss. No matter how powerful the

Jin Family of Taiyuan is, we're still nowhere near enough to stand before the name of the Zhongnan Sect."

Ju Hwaran's eyelids fluttered with surprise, then lowered.

I could feel her sinking into resignation.

But I was not finished.

"I kept thinking the same thing on the way here. Wondering whether this was really the right choice, or whether I should pretend I knew nothing and keep walking."

"Young Hero Jin, you can stop. Please, that's enough."

"No."

I shook my head.

"At first, I thought I was doing this because your face kept coming to mind. But…"

I turned and found Hwangbo Eom watching me with an amused smile.

The Zhongnan Sect was one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, and Hwangbo Eom was its elder and most powerful martial artist.

His martial arts were higher and his personality more meticulous, but Hwangbo Eom was still the same kind of person as the Roaring Fury Swordsman.

I stared straight at this second Roaring Fury Swordsman and opened my mouth.

"It felt like fucking bullshit."

"…!"

"…!"

Even without seeing it, I could feel the energy in the room stirring.

I continued with a sigh.

"'Upright.' That's why you're called the orthodox faction. But there's nothing upright about this, is there? If you're going to act like this, use the *jeong* from Choco Pie instead. Why the fuck would you use the *jeong* that means 'upright'?"[1654]

Never once in my life had I thought of myself as a good person.

I had become a Hunter for money, and in the Murim, I had even considered abandoning someone to save my own life.

I was a murky gray. Nothing more, nothing less.

Yet now, a thought suddenly occurred to me.

"Maybe I was pretty white after all. Why else would I go this far?"

"You insolent little—!"

"Great Hero Hwangbo."

I smiled at Hwangbo Eom as he prepared to roar.

[1654] This is a pun on *jeong*, the Korean word associated with affection in Choco Pie's famous slogan, contrasted with the *jeong* in "orthodox," which means upright or righteous.

“I told you earlier, didn’t I? Even when everything seems over, something unexpected can suddenly pop up and throw it all into disarray.”

I slowly reached out and tapped the empty air.

No one else could see it, but I could.

Hwangbo Eom’s dominoes were tumbling one after another.

“I’m not even your grandson, Great Hero Hwangbo. Why else would I spend this long talking to an eighty-year-old grandfather?”

For an instant, Hwangbo Eom looked dumbfounded. Then his face twisted violently.

He had sensed it too—the presences of several people rapidly approaching the teahouse.

“You bastard. What the hell are you plotting?”

“You’re the one who pulled a trick. I…”

I turned my head and finished.

“I made a plan.”

That was the moment the teahouse’s doors opened and about a dozen people came streaming inside.

First came five beggars carrying a mountain of bamboo slips[1655] in their arms. They were the Xi’an Branch Leader of the Beggars’ Sect and his subordinates.

At the head of the other group stood a woman I knew well.

“Congratulations on your promotion. It’s been a while.”

“Oh, my Young Master. A congratulatory greeting after an entire year? How prompt of you.”

Wolhwa, Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect’s Shaanxi branch, playfully arched one pretty eyebrow.

[1655] Bamboo slips are strips of bamboo used as a writing surface, often bound together to form documents.

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Wolhwa seemed even more beautiful than she had been a year ago.

Dressed in dazzling clothes and wearing an alluring smile, she approached with the grace of a peacock and placed a hand on my shoulder.

“Our Young Master Jin. You’ve gotten even more dashing since I last saw you.”

At least this part of her hadn’t changed.

I let out a quiet laugh and pushed her hand away.

“You haven’t changed a bit.”

“I’m hurt. After a whole year, is that all you have to say?”

“Hmm. I suppose you’ve gotten a little prettier, too.”

“It feels like I had to fish for that compliment myself, but… fine. You pass. Dropping everything and rushing over here was worth it after all.”

As Wolhwa flashed me one of her signature eye-smiles, a young beggar in shabby clothes approached from beside her with a sour expression.

The cord at his waist, marking him as a disciple of the Beggars’ Sect, was tied into three knots.

In other words, he was a three-knot Disciple.

“I’m the Heukgeol Beggar, head of the Beggars’ Sect’s Xi’an branch.”

“Yes, I’m from the Jin Family of Taiyuan—”

“I already know. You’re as strapping as I’d heard. With a face like that, you could easily earn dozens of silver nyang[1656] a day begging. Have you ever considered joining the Beggars’ Sect?”

“…”

“Well, forget it if you’re not interested. In any case, it seems someone who should be here is missing.”

Huff, huff.

Heukgeol Beggar blew hard through his nose as he looked around. The moment he spotted his target, he shouted.

“Gung Gibang! You son of a bitch!”

When did that bastard get over there?

Gung Gibang was already crouched beneath a table some distance away. He gave us an awkward smile.

“Oh, look. My old friend of twenty years, Big Nose, is here. What brings you here?”

“I told you not to call me Big Nose! And what brings me here? You miserable bastard! I warned you over and over to make sure this didn’t happen, but you went and did it anyway…!”

[1656] A nyang was a historical Korean unit of currency. “Silver nyang” specifies its silver denomination.

Heukgeol Beggar furiously shook the wooden slip in his hand.

Beneath the message telling him to gather the necessary information and come to Tengwang Pavilion, eight yellow hairs had been attached. They had apparently been plucked from some stray dog passing through the neighborhood.

Anyone else would have wondered what the hairs were supposed to mean, but according to Gung Gibang, they were the mark of an eight-knot disciple of the Beggars' Sect.

In other words, the mark of the Successor Beggar.

"Ahem. I told you, I couldn't help it."

"Damn it. If the Law Beggar comes looking for you over this, remember that it's all your fault."

"Now, now. You have a lot to say for a mere three-knot Disciple. You should be attending to the Successor Beggar instead."

"You're no Successor Beggar. You're a successor mutt."

Despite his words, Heukgeol Beggar reached out and pulled away a chair so Gung Gibang could climb out more easily.

Judging from their conversation, the two had been close friends since their days as young beggars.

Even better. This should go smoothly.

For someone else, however, it would be very bad news.

I turned my head and found Hwangbo Eom's face twisted with displeasure. The corners of my mouth rose of their own accord.

"If this is your first time meeting, you should at least exchange greetings. Both of them do very important work here in Shaanxi Province."

The Zhongnan Sect could not compare to Huashan, but its position in Shaanxi Province was by no means insignificant.

There was no way Hwangbo Eom did not know the branch leaders of the Beggars' Sect and the Lower District Sect. I had only added that last part to sour his mood.

"You…"

Just as I had expected, Hwangbo Eom already knew who they were. He bit his lip. His fingers twitched as though he wanted nothing more than to draw the sword propped beside the table and start swinging.

Go ahead. Draw it.

But Hwangbo Eom was not nearly as easy to provoke as the Roaring Fury Swordsman.

The sly old man's eyes slowly turned cold.

"What the hell are you doing?"

The answer came from behind me.

“I know, right? My heart is already pounding with anticipation over what our Young Master Jin might do next.”

Hwangbo Eom glared sharply at Wolhwa, who had spoken without warning.

“This is not a matter for the Lower District Sect. I do not know why you came here, but… it would be best for you to withdraw now.”

“Great Hero Hwangbo, I’m sorry, but I don’t think I can do that.”

Wolhwa continued with a radiant smile.

“I’ve already accepted a commission. Of course, the client is Young Master Jin, standing right here. Isn’t that right?”

“Oh, absolutely. Did you receive the silver nyang[1657] retainer I sent through the attendant?”

“Of course I did. But one silver nyang[1658] is terribly stingy. I’ll collect a generous fee from you later, so be prepared.”

I had no idea how much she intended to fleece me for, but that was a problem for later.

Hwangbo Eom silently glared at Wolhwa and me as we chatted amiably. His next target was Heukgeol Beggar.

“And what does the Beggars’ Sect intend to do?”

“Great Hero Hwangbo, this is quite a predicament.”

Heukgeol Beggar scratched his lice-ridden head and bowed deeply.

“I’m sorry, but it’s not a matter I can do anything about.”

“Is that the will of the Beggars’ Sect?”

Heukgeol Beggar bent at the waist in alarm.

“What? Oh, heavens, no. How could a mere three-knot Disciple like me presume to speak for the Beggars’ Sect?”

“Then withdraw, unless you wish to make an enemy of our sect.”

“Well, the thing is, we have sect rules on our side, too. That might be difficult.”

“You call that an excuse?”

“It isn’t an excuse. It’s the truth. Isn’t that right? No, wouldn’t you say so, Successor Beggar?”

Gung Gibang avoided Hwangbo Eom’s gaze and nodded.

“Well, yes.”

“This old man went easy on you because you were a young prodigy of the Beggars’ Sect, but you’ve gone too far…”

Hwangbo Eom looked back and forth between the two, then shouted like a thunderclap.

“Enough excuses! Beggars’ Sect, will you get the hell out of here already?”

[1657] A nyang was a historical Korean unit of currency. “Silver nyang” specifies its silver denomination.

[1658] A nyang was a historical Korean unit of currency. “Silver nyang” specifies its silver denomination.

Boom!

With a furious roar, Hwangbo Eom slammed his palm into the center of the table.

A low rumble rolled through the room. Unable to withstand his profound internal energy, the table was punched clean through, leaving a hole shaped like his palm.

And then…

“Well now.”

“This is something.”

At that moment, the atmosphere around the bowing Gung Gibang and Heukgeol Beggar changed.

The two men looked at each other’s grime-covered faces and let out quiet laughs.

“Hey, Gibang. I guess we really are beggars. Even here, people treat us like beggars.”

“Tell me about it. I’m in a lousy mood today, too. Should we just call every beggar in Shaanxi Province?”

“As the branch leader, that’s my job. If we gathered only the ones in Xi’an, we’d still have about a thousand.”

“That’s not your call, three-knot. I’m an eight-knot—the one and only eight-knot disciple in the Beggars’ Sect! If the Successor Beggar calls, they’ll come running even from the neighboring province.”

“Shaanxi will become a den of beggars. At that point, wouldn’t it be looting rather than begging?”

“Now, now, what do you mean, looting? I hear there’s a great deal of food on Mount Zhongnan… While we’re at it, let’s wipe out every edible thing there.”

It wasn’t Alibaba and the Forty Thieves.[1659]

It was Gung Gibang and ten thousand beggars.

I already knew that the Beggars’ Sect was a great sect with a hundred thousand disciples, but hearing them talk about it made me want to piss myself.

At the very least, they’d be a swarm of locusts.

If ten thousand beggars swept over Mount Zhongnan, it would become a desert within a month. The complete annihilation of the mountain wildlife would be a given, and they would strip away every edible blade of grass and shred of bark.

“Y-you bastards, what kind of nonsense are you spouting…?”

Hwangbo Eom’s wrinkled hand trembled.

“Do you think this old man would stand by and watch such a thing happen? I will personally demand that the Gang Leader punish both of you!”

“Do as you wish. My Master will beat me within an inch of my life, but surely he won’t kill his only Disciple. However…”

[1659] *Alibaba and the Forty Thieves* is a tale in the *One Thousand and One Nights* tradition featuring a band of forty robbers.

Gung Gibang was no longer the man who had been inching backward, trying to escape. His voice had settled low, deeper than a swamp.

"As the Successor Beggar of the Beggars' Sect, I have issued an order to the Xi'an branch. And only two people under heaven can rescind an order from the Successor Beggar: the Dragon-Head Gang Leader, who commands our hundred thousand disciples, and the Law Beggar, who enforces the sect rules."

"…!"

"My Master, the Dragon-Head Gang Leader, has told me again and again: we may not have homes, but does that mean we have no pride? Great Hero Hwangbo, you have insulted a beggar's pride."

A veteran beggar, all right.

It wasn't easy to look that cool and that pathetic at the same time, but he pulled it off effortlessly.

Maybe he really is good at begging.

With a voice brimming with tragic grandeur and words that made him sound utterly pitiable, Gung Gibang dominated the room before turning to Heukgeol Beggar.

"You brought everything I listed in the letter, right?"

"How could I fail to, when it was the Successor Beggar's order?"

At Heukgeol Beggar's gesture, the Beggars' Sect disciples from the Xi'an branch who had been waiting behind him began neatly stacking the bamboo slips they had brought.

There were a full hundred of them.

But that was not all.

"What are you all waiting for? It's time to get to work."

At the sound of Wolhwa's alluring voice, the Lower District Sect members who had been standing quietly nearby placed bundles of paper beside the bamboo slips.

There were nearly as many bundles as there were bamboo slips.

The sight before him made Hwangbo Eom's face go rigid.

"Wh-what is all this?"

I gazed fondly at the bamboo slips and sheets of paper.

"Nothing comes to mind? For example… the Yongbong Escort Bureau's unending run of bad luck over the past two years."

"…!"

"Let's swim upstream like salmon and retrace the past. And while we're at it, let's find out how the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng that had been on its way here without a problem managed to vanish without a trace."

The energies of two people thrashed with the vigor of salmon fighting upstream.

One was Hwangbo Eom, overwhelmed by confusion.

The other was Ju Hwaran.

Her luminous eyes, frozen cold without a trace of anger or excitement, turned toward Hwangbo Eom.

“So that’s what happened after all.”

“Did you know?”

“How could I not? I suspected it all along, but I had no choice but to let it happen.”

“Because we were up against one of the Nine Sects and One Gang.”

Her voice drifted weakly into the empty air.

For the past two years, the Zhongnan Sect had manipulated the Yongbong Escort Bureau’s failures from the shadows. Someone who did not know the circumstances might say that she had brought down the Escort Bureau in a mere two years, but that would be wrong.

The Yongbong Escort Bureau had already been a listing ship, and Ju Hwaran had become its captain before she was even twenty.

It was thanks to her ability that the bureau had held firm until now, despite the threat of the enormous monster known as the Zhongnan Sect.

But now… everything would be different.

“You’ve been through a lot.”

At my brief words, Ju Hwaran bit her lip tightly.

And what she chose was not tears, but a smile.

“Thank you, Young Hero Jin. But I’ll hear that after this escort mission is over.”

She was right.

Just as Ju Hwaran had said, the Yongbong Escort Bureau’s escort mission was not over yet.

I gave Heukgeol Beggar and Wolhwa a small nod.

“Let’s begin.”

Hwangbo Eom suddenly wondered.

What is happening?

Everything had been proceeding smoothly. He had taken each step carefully over the past two years, and all that remained was to bring it to a close.

There had been a time when he thought so.

He truly had.

“Last summer, the Yongbong Escort Bureau suffered a loss of one thousand silver nyang[1660] when its deal with the Geumo Merchant Guild fell through. A man

[1660] A nyang was a historical Korean unit of currency. “Silver nyang” specifies its silver denomination.

named Hwang Cheolsim secretly intervened in the process. According to what our sect uncovered, he was a lay disciple of Zhongnan, and…”

The voices reaching Hwangbo Eom’s ears felt distant and unfamiliar.

Most of the information uncovered by the Lower District Sect and the Beggars’ Sect was true.

By cross-checking their findings, they had confirmed the facts more thoroughly and uncovered new incidents. One lead grew into the next without end, like the stem of a plant.

This is impossible.

Hwangbo Eom stood frozen like a statue, repeating the same thought over and over.

Then one person entered his field of vision.

The corners of his mouth were raised. His clear eyes seemed capable of seeing straight through the human heart.

Jin Taekyung was laughing at him.

It’s all that bastard’s fault. If only he hadn’t been there, if only…!

People said that Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom was different from his two martial brothers.

But they were wrong.

At this very moment, Hwangbo Eom’s mind was being bleached white by rage.

The cold, poisonous heart that had occupied that space was gone. In its place was something even worse—a murderous intent that filled him to the brim.

“You bastard—!”

Shiiing!

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space.

The scabbard flew into Hwangbo Eom’s grasp, and a silver line burst from it.

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It all happened in an instant.

The qi permeating the air surged, and the sword propped against the table flew into one man's waiting hand.

And then…

Shuaaaak!

A dazzling streak of light filled my vision. The strike was impossibly fast and precise.

The blue qi crystallized around the blade and scattered a brilliant radiance. I already knew another name for that light.

Sword Force.

A power granted only to those who had stepped into the Supreme Peak realm. Stronger than anything else in the world, it was falling straight toward the crown of my head.

At this rate, I'll die. No question about it.

But…

This isn't nearly enough.

In a world slowed to a crawl, I moved—and the Sword Force split the air.

Shlick! Kraaash!

Everything was cleaved apart. The table, the chairs, even the floor of the teahouse that must have stood there for countless years.

The gale unleashed by the Sword Force swept through the room. Screams and thunderous crashes swallowed everything. Beyond them, I saw the old man's eyes stretched wide.

"H-how did you…"

I gently pushed Ju Hwaran, whom I had pulled into my arms, to the side and answered.

"How did I dodge it? I saw it coming, so I dodged."

"…"

"People say the Supreme Peak realm—and Sword Force—belong to a realm beyond humanity."

Unconcealed shock spread across Hwangbo Eom's wrinkled face.

"Th-then could it be that you…!"

"Who knows?"

I answered with a faint smile. By now, thunder must have been crashing through Hwangbo Eom's head.

Of course, I had not gained the enlightenment required to reach the Supreme Peak realm.

To be precise, it wasn't my martial arts but my physical abilities themselves that had reached a realm beyond humanity.

What should I even call this?

A Supreme Peak master—physically?

There was no doubt that I was a new kind of Supreme Peak master, one without precedent in the history of the Murim.

I shrugged.

"It's nothing special. I tried it, and it worked."

Hwangbo Eom shouted, his eyes bloodshot.

"I refuse to believe this! How can a brat like you have reached such a realm?"

"I find it hard to believe, too. Who swings a sword in a place like this? Are you out of your mind?"

"That…"

Hwangbo Eom's eyes stiffened as they swept across the room.

Fortunately, his strike had been aimed precisely at me, so no one else had been injured. Even so, every face around us showed shock and fury.

"You went on about the orthodox faction and the Great Zhongnan Sect, but the second you lost your temper, you became no better than a fiend. Why not rename yourselves the Zhong-Bastard Sect while you're at it?"

"You—!"

Hwangbo Eom's hand trembled around the sword hilt. His conflicted gaze swept over the room before turning cold.

"Disciples of the Zhongnan Sect, heed my command."

"Y-yes, Martial Uncle!"

The thirty members of the Taeeul Sword Unit, frozen like statues by the sudden turn of events, jolted back to their senses.

They hurriedly cupped their hands[1661], and Hwangbo Eom's command fell over their heads.

"Seal the entrances immediately. No one is to leave this place."

"S-Senior Martial Uncle!"

"B-but…"

"What are you waiting for? Do you intend to disobey this old man's command?"

As Hwangbo Eom's roar left the Taeeul Sword Unit hesitating, a quiet voice pierced everyone's ears.

"Yes. I do."

[1661] *Pogwon* is a formal martial salute made by enclosing one fist in the opposite hand.

Hwangbo Eom's face filled with fury when he recognized the speaker.

"Hyuk Sopyung. How dare you…"

I knew the young man. Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan One Dragon.

He stared at Hwangbo Eom with an indescribably complicated look in his eyes.

"Please stop. This is the first and last time I will beg you."

"What did you say?"

"The way you're acting right now, Senior Martial Uncle… Isn't this beneath a disciple of the Great Zhongnan Sect?"

"Shut your mouth!"

Kraaash!

Another gale swept through the room, and Hyuk Sopyung's body slid backward.

But his gaze did not waver.

Hwangbo Eom looked back and forth between Hyuk Sopyung and the thirty hesitant members of the Taeeul Sword Unit, then bit down hard on his lip.

"You little…"

The next moment, he pulled a small copper tablet from inside his robes and threw it at Hyuk Sopyung's feet.

"This is our sect's Sect Leader's Command Token, entrusted to this old man by your Master. Do you still intend to refuse?"

"…!"

The Sect Leader's Command Token was a powerful symbol of the authority held by the leader of a sect.

Hyuk Sopyung's eyelids trembled when he recognized his Master's copper tablet.

"Senior Martial Uncle, you truly haven't changed."

"Choose. Expulsion or obedience."

"Expulsion…"

Hyuk Sopyung's regretful gaze settled on Ju Hwaran and me.

Then he gave a bitter smile, prostrated himself before the copper tablet, and slammed his forehead against the floor.

Thud! Thud! Thud!

"Disciple Hyuk Sopyung obeys the Sect Leader's Command Token!"

His cry sounded as if he were vomiting blood. Blood streamed down his split forehead.

Hyuk Sopyung rose with a blank expression, as if he felt no pain at all, and blocked the entrance to the teahouse. The thirty members of the Taeeul Sword Unit followed suit.

I clicked my tongue as I watched it all unfold.

“At this point, you haven’t just crossed the line—you erased it altogether. Are you sure you can deal with the consequences?”

Major figures from Huashan, the Beggars’ Sect, and the Lower District Sect were all gathered here. No matter how powerful the Zhongnan Sect was, the fallout from today would be fierce.

But Hwangbo Eom had already lost his mind. His eyes held nothing but rage.

“They will come to no harm. All except you.”

“Ah. So you’ll deal with me first and clean up afterward?”

“Yes. At last, I can tear that mouth of yours apart.”

“Why are you so desperate to tear it apart, old man? The Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Fire Gate Clan aren’t exactly a pair of pushover nobodies.”

“The Fire Gate Clan?”

A sneer formed at the corner of Hwangbo Eom’s mouth.

The next moment, a line of Sound Transmission pierced my ear.

—The young tiger is in danger, yet the great tiger shows no sign of waking.

“…!”

—Did you think this old man wouldn’t know, you foolish child? I already knew the Fire King’s illness was grave.

A secret known to only a handful of people had leaked out.

My face stiffened before I could stop it. Hwangbo Eom’s smile deepened when he saw my reaction.

—The Fire King Jeok Cheongang, and you. I have had more than enough of you both. This might be a good opportunity to settle my bad blood with the Fire Gate Clan once and for all.

Settle his bad blood?

Hwangbo Eom’s words left me momentarily dazed.

Does he mean what I think he means?

My tangled thoughts vanished in an instant. Only one remained.

“Sorry, but can I ask everyone for one favor?”

I could feel their gazes even without looking.

Baek Museong and Cheongpung. Gung Gibang and Heukgeol Beggar. Wolhwa and Hyuk Mujin. And finally, Ju Hwaran.

Everyone in the room was looking at me.

Then a voice so dry that I could hardly believe it belonged to me slipped between my lips.

“Block the entrance. Don’t let anyone get out.”

Hwangbo Eom had been the first to block the door, but I would be the one to decide when it opened and closed.

“Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom.”

I let out a quiet sigh. Extreme Yang qi boiled up from my dantian and flowed from me as white steam.

"You… said something you never should have."

He should never have brought up Jeok Cheongang over something as trivial as this.

He truly shouldn't have.

Starting now, he would pay the price for saying what should never have been said.

"Come at me, you fucking old bastard."

In time split into smaller and smaller instants, Hwangbo Eom and I rushed toward each other.

Kraaaaaash!

Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords.

A dense and powerful net of Sword Energy covered heaven and earth in every direction.

The sword forms came without pause, on a completely different level from those of the Roaring Fury Swordsman I had faced a year ago or Hyuk Sopyung the day before.

Shishishishishik!

They were blindingly fast and destructive. Even a glancing blow would split flesh and bone and bring death.

I can't dodge this. There's no way.

At least, it would have been true if I were the me from a year ago.

The saying *wipe your eyes and look again* came to mind—a phrase for progress so astonishing that you had to rub your eyes and take another look.

Even that fell short of describing me.

Through endless days of brutal training, I had grown stronger. No, it would not be wrong to call it evolution.

Heaven is truly heartless. How can someone like you even exist?

Jeok Cheongang's face, filled with helpless disbelief, appeared over the net of Sword Energy.

I laughed quietly and swept my spear, White Flame, upward.

Shraaaak!

The Extreme Yang qi coating White Flame's spearhead tore through the net.

A fish would have fled through the gap in the torn net, but I was no fish.

I was a shark.

The fisherman who had cast the net had clearly overlooked that fact.

The old fisherman's wrinkled face filled with shock.

"You—!"

I did not answer.

I bent my knees and lowered my waist. The spear in my hand curved smoothly like a dragon's tail.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Fwoooosh! Boom!

The blue-burning spear and sword collided. A deafening crash rang out as an immense shock wave erupted.

Had Hwangbo Eom been trying to conserve his strength?

If so, he had made a terrible mistake. No matter how severely it drained his internal energy, he should have used Sword Force.

"Hup!"

His eyes opened wide.

The old man staggered before my strength, which had entered the realm beyond humanity, and the innate ferocity of my martial art.

"Wh-what kind of martial art is this…?"

The founder of the Fire Gate Clan had been called the greatest martial artist under heaven in his era.

He created the Fire Gate Divine Technique and made it the root of the clan. The sixteen Sect Leaders who followed became different branches growing from that same root.

The Fire Dragon Divine Spear was no different.

Created by the fifth Sect Leader, the spear art was supremely destructive and fierce. Its movements truly resembled those of a fire dragon.

And…

This is only the beginning.

Whoooosh!

I held nothing back.

I thrust, slashed, swept, and struck.

Whenever the blue flames ran wild, thunderous crashes like the sky splitting apart shook heaven and earth.

After the tail come the claws.

No one under heaven had ever seen a dragon fight.

But while learning the Fire Dragon Divine Spear, I had found myself wondering.

If a fire dragon really swung its claws, wouldn't it look exactly like this?

Gooooong.

Extreme Yang qi coiled around the tip of my spear.

The tea spilled across the floor during Hwangbo Eom's earlier rampage had long since evaporated. The jade-colored tea set glowed red-hot, as if it were back inside the kiln where it had been fired.

Sensing that something was wrong, Hwangbo Eom shouted like a thunderbolt.

"You bastard!"

He was already nearing eighty.

But to someone who had entered the Supreme Peak realm, age was nothing more than a number.

His formidable internal energy and the Zhongnan Sect's ultimate techniques, honed for more than a jiazi[1662], poured down like beams of light.

Swoooosh!

If the Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords were a net, this was a harpoon meant to finish its prey.

As his sword slashed toward my chest at incredible speed, scattering dozens of afterimages, one martial art flashed through my mind.

Taeeul Light-Dividing Sword.

One of the Zhongnan Sect's most celebrated ultimate sword techniques.

Jeok Cheongang had described the Taeeul Light-Dividing Sword as a sword art of extreme speed.

Then he had added one more thing.

Maybe this old man is going senile. Why do I get the feeling you'll be faster than the sword?

If Jeok Cheongang woke up, I wanted to tell him he had been right.

And that the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts had shattered the Taeeul Light-Dividing Sword.

Heavenly Strike.

The fire dragon swung its claws.

The strike descended from the sky, erasing the afterimages created by the Taeeul Light-Dividing Sword as it fell like a bolt of lightning.

Kraaaaaash!

A pillar of hellfire erupted.

[1662] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

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Kraaaaaash!

The hellfire surged outward, devouring the lingering chill of early spring.

It erased the dozens of wavering afterimages created by the Taeeul Light-Dividing Sword and finally struck the blade as they converged into one.

The Sword Force, the one true essence and concentration of power, collided with the hellfire.

Goooooooong!

A deafening roar rang out as a massive wave of martial energy spiraled around the old man and the young man.

Blue flames twisted through the wind, tore through the tea house's ceiling, and surged skyward like a waterspout.

At the sight, Hwangbo Eom's eyelids trembled.

The fire dragon…!

He did not even notice that his prized white beard had been scorched black.

Beyond their locked weapons, the young man's burning eyes glared into his. The sight stole his breath and left his chest tight.

It's hot.

Hwangbo Eom possessed two jiazi[1663] of internal energy and had reached the Supreme Peak realm.

His body, tempered by formidable martial arts, had long since reached the state of being Unaffected by Cold and Heat.

But the young man's gaze—and the aura radiating from him—could not be described as mere heat.

Rage and fighting spirit.

And within them, the faintest trace of cold composure.

How can this be? He is little more than a boy…

"Cough."

A dry cough escaped Hwangbo Eom, followed by a mouthful of blood. His trembling gaze fell upon the spear in the young man's hand.

Blue-white flames coiled around its transparent silver spearhead.

It was not yet complete, but it was unmistakably Force.

No. That's not possible. He hasn't crossed the wall yet. Then how could this old man…?

Hwangbo Eom had crossed that wall ten years ago and entered the Supreme Peak realm.

[1663] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Two jiazi of internal energy means roughly 120 years' worth.

Yet despite the enlightenment he had gained through all those years of training and meditation, he was being pushed back by a young brat still confined to the Peak realm.

"How…?"

The young man's answer was short.

"Because I'm stronger."

"…!"

With that quiet reply, the spearhead locked against Hwangbo Eom's sword bore down on him with tremendous force.

Kaga-ga-ga-gak!

"Hup!"

Two jiazi[1664] of internal energy poured into his Sword Force?

A martial art of the Supreme Peak realm?

None of it mattered. The power transmitted through the spearhead was divine strength beyond anything a human should have been able to wield. It called to mind a myth he had heard as a child.

Pangu.

The primordial giant who had created the world with a single swing of his ax.

The young man before him had confined the strength of a god within a human body.

And divine strength was not all he possessed.

Shlick!

The senses of a Supreme Peak master far surpassed those of an ordinary martial artist.

Yet even Hwangbo Eom could not evade the silver line that suddenly slashed across him.

Pain he had not felt in decades.

Blood spurted from his shoulder, and his eyes flew wide.

When did he…?

He had not even seen the young man strike.

Even the Taeeul Light-Dividing Sword, the Zhongnan Sect's celebrated sword art of extreme speed, could not possibly be like this.

After eighty years spent practicing the Zhongnan Sect's martial arts, Hwangbo Eom cried out.

"This cannot be! It cannot!"

Kraaa-boom!

[1664] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Two jiazi of internal energy means roughly 120 years' worth.

He summoned every last ounce of strength, and the Force gathered along his blade flared like wildfire.

At last escaping the pressure, Hwangbo Eom pointed at the young man with trembling fingers.

“Who… Who in the world are you?”

“You know.”

The young man, Jin Taekyung, spat to the side like a common street thug before continuing.

“The nineteenth successor of the Fire Gate Clan.”

Fwoooosh!

The hellfire gathered around the transparent spearhead blazed fiercely.

Shweeeeeek! Boom!

Spearhead and sword blade collided.

In a succession of instants, hellfire and Sword Force erased everything in their path as they clashed and separated through dozens of exchanges.

Shishishishik! Bang!

I tilted my head a fraction.

A tremendous wave of martial energy erupted from the sword tip as it stabbed through empty air. A pillar three jang[1665] away split like tofu and came crashing down.

I launched myself forward, bounding across the wooden fragments raining from the ceiling.

Light yet heavy.

Soft yet rough.

Like a fire spreading.

So this is the essence of the Flamefire Path.

For an instant, weightlessness enveloped my entire body.

The world slowed around me, and I alone raced forward as though being pulled along. My body, light as air, shot ahead like a bullet.

Ding.

[1665] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

SYSTEM

Enlightenment comes to you in many ways: through ceaseless training and meditation, and through battles in which you stake your life.
The Flamefire Path has risen to seven stars!
You have gained a substantial amount of EXP!

Bang!

Air exploded beneath my toes.

The moment the System notification rang out, I was right in front of Hwangbo Eom.

Maybe it was the unexpected enlightenment and my newfound speed, but I had gotten too close to thrust my spear.

Instead of retreating, I struck out with my palm.

Whoooosh!

My palm burned through the air.

Hwangbo Eom roared like thunder and thrust out his own palm to meet it.

A dazzling blue light gathered over his wrinkled palm.

It was the Zhongnan Sect's famed Blue Cloud Heavenly Force Palm.

But he had too little time to complete the Force in his palm.

No.

I was faster.

Whooooooosh! Boom!

Our palms collided.

A thunderous crash rang out, followed by a strangled groan.

Hwangbo Eom's face had gone pale from his Internal Injury. Gritting his teeth, he raised his other hand and pointed it at me.

Papapap!

Five streams of Finger Qi sliced uselessly through empty air.

If I hadn't seized his wrist with the Fire Dragon Claw in that split second, I would have been the one bleeding.

How dare you.

Crack.

I twisted his captured wrist between my thumb, index finger, and middle finger.

A muffled scream slipped through his cracked lips.

Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom.

How long had it been since he had felt pain like this?

When the curtain falls, the actors leave the stage.

The curtain had fallen on the war between the orthodox and unorthodox factions half a century ago, and its heroes had scattered.

The Hwangbo Eom I saw before me now was no hero.

He was nothing but a petty old man.

This is going to hurt.

I released his limp wrist.

At the same time, I curled the fingers that had been bent like a dragon's claws into a fist.

Crack.

Day after day, I had repeated the same stance countless times with an iron ball weighing hundreds of geun[1666] strapped to me.

My lower body rooted like a tree. My waist stood like a pillar. My fist flew true and unhindered.

Not one inch of my stance deviated from Jeok Cheongang's teachings.

At first, I shattered rocks.

Then I split waterfalls plunging from hundreds of jang[1667] above.

And brought down cliffs.

The back of my hand, burst and split countless times until it resembled a turtle's shell, became wreathed in blue-white flame.

The time it took to assume the stance and throw the punch was truly no more than an instant.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Gooooong.

The Extreme Yang energy evaporated every trace of moisture within several meters[1668].

Hwangbo Eom's lips, cracked like a drought-stricken rice paddy, parted.

"No—!"

"It can."

With that answer, I drove my fist forward.

The Body-Protecting Qi of a Supreme Peak master blocked its path—but only for a moment. The punch shattered the energy surrounding his entire body and slammed into his aged flesh and bones.

Kraaaack!

"Gaaaaaaaaah!"

Hwangbo Eom's body was hurled backward amid a shriek that seemed to tear the air apart.

[1666] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb).

[1667] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1668] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

Three pillars and part of the wall collapsed, and the remaining ceiling came crashing down.

Just as the word *finished* crossed my mind, I saw bloodshot eyes glaring at me through the cloud of dust.

“C-cough!”

“Stay down if you want to hold on to what little life you have left.”

“You… How could you…”

Shock and confusion.

Rage and humiliation.

Countless emotions churned in Hwangbo Eom’s eyes.

At last, they all converged into one.

Hatred.

His blood-soaked lips slowly parted.

Blood mixed with pieces of his organs poured down, but his eyes continued to burn fiercely.

They were the eyes of a man who no longer cared what happened afterward.

“This old man is… The First Sword of Zhongnan.”

At that moment, the hot wind swirling around us cooled.

Then an icy wind began to blow.

It came from one man and rose from a single sword.

I felt my overheated blood begin to cool and muttered,

“This is…”

“The Taeeul Formless Sword. Watch closely. This is the sword art that will take your life.”

Shing—

The sword moved, and the wind blew.

The sword was the wind, and the wind was the sword.

Invisible sword strikes hid within it.

The sharp smell of blood suddenly filled my nose.

Shlick!

I stepped half a pace to the side.

That half-step saved my life.

I had no time even to register the blood running down my neck. Every time Hwangbo Eom’s sword vibrated from more than ten jang[1669] away, invisible sword strikes surged toward me like waves.

Shik, shlick!

My side stung.

[1669] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The energy carried by the sword strike rattled my insides.

Even as I staggered, I raised my arm. The attack missed by a hair and split a roof beam like tofu.

What is this?

Shlick!

There was no time to wonder.

This time, a long gash opened across my chest. Blood sprayed out and soaked the floor.

I can't see them.

It felt as if I had been swallowed by dense fog.

This was not a matter of strength or speed.

This was martial arts—a sword art of supreme mastery unleashed by a martial artist who had attained greater enlightenment than I had, even at the cost of driving his internal energy berserk.

And yet…

How have I managed to dodge them until now?

The question seized my mind.

Dozens of sword strikes rained down on my rigid body.

I stared at them blankly.

Then I closed my eyes.

In the darkness, one man's face appeared.

His sharp, ringing voice echoed faintly.

In the Murim, keep your eyes wide open. Then you won't get stabbed and die.

What if I end up in danger of dying anyway?

Then rip out those useless eyes and see with your heart.

My heart? Come on. How is that supposed to work?

Have you even tried?

Yes, I had.

No. I was trying now.

So this is what you meant back then.

A smile spread across my face without my realizing it.

I couldn't see them.

But I could feel them.

The sword strikes approaching through the darkness, where I could not see even an inch ahead.

Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom's final struggle.

Thank you for the lesson, Old Master.

With my eyes still closed, I twisted my body.

I tuned every limb and every tiny muscle as precisely as the notes of a piano.

The sword strikes missed my flesh, tearing through my clothes and gouging the ground.

Kraaa-boom!

Amid the thunderous crash, I slowly opened my eyes.

Hwangbo Eom's face was filled with shock.

An emotion I had never seen before gleamed in his eyes.

Fear.

He knew it, too.

He knew the fear he was feeling.

The terror he felt from me.

"D-don't come any closer!"

Shweeeek!

I took one step forward and swung my spear.

The sword strike sweeping toward my neck collided with the spearhead and vanished.

Then I took another step.

Shishishishing!

I wielded my spear as naturally as I breathed.

I knocked the attacks aside, blocked them, and pierced them as if dispatching living enemies.

All the while, my feet never stopped.

I was in no hurry.

Hwangbo Eom was desperate.

Ignoring the body that had already reached its limit, he unleashed one final sword strike.

Kraaaaaash!

Sword Force carrying enough power to reduce the entire tea house to dust rushed toward me.

I watched until it was right before my eyes.

Then I swung my spearhead like a bolt of lightning.

Heavenly Strike.

The fire dragon's claw seized the Sword Force.

And in the next instant—

Crack!

The shattered blade tumbled across the ground.

Hwangbo Eom stared blankly at his ruined, cherished sword before raising his head.

“You… What in the world are you…”

“So why…”

I slowly continued speaking to the greatest martial artist of the Zhongnan Sect, Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom.

“Why the fuck did you have to insult someone else’s master? You old bastard who ate all those years through your asshole. You trying to get yourself killed? Fuck.”

Chapter 325

A shudder.

That was the emotion everyone present shared.

Huashan, the Beggars' Sect, the Zhongnan Sect, the Lower District Sect, and even the Yongbong Escort Bureau. Dozens of trembling pairs of eyes stared dumbfoundedly at the scene unfolding before them.

"So."

Thwack!

"While I was still asking nicely."

Thwack!

"You should've stopped."

Thwack!

"Where do you get off throwing the first punch—the first sword, even?"

Craack!

The final blow was especially loud. With a wet, choking rattle of blood in his throat, the old man crumpled to the ground.

His face was covered in blood. The sharp bridge of his nose, which had once made countless women's hearts flutter, had long since been flattened, and the even teeth that had belied his eighty years had been reduced to a single front tooth.

"You talk shit about someone else's Master like you're insulting their fucking dad, you piece of shit."

Craack!

The last remaining front tooth went flying through the air and landed in a corner of the tea house.

As everyone stared at the scene in stunned disbelief, a single thought flashed through their minds.

What the hell am I looking at?

Something no one had thought would happen—something that should never have happened—was happening right before their eyes.

Who would believe that a young man barely twenty years old, only just beginning to make a name for himself in the martial world, was beating the Zhongnan Sect's greatest master and the Sect Leader's senior martial brother to a pulp?

And yet everyone present had witnessed it with their own eyes.

They had seen the exchange between two men whose movements had been too fast to follow. And at the end of that exchange, the fallen old man and the young man standing alone.

"The fire dragon…"

Someone muttered those two words like a groan, and they sank deep into everyone’s hearts.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi. That was the martial name by which the young man Jin Taekyung had been known in the Murim.

But it was wrong. The Hidden Dragon had finally risen, and he would soar through the skies of the entire world—not merely those of Shanxi.

As a fire dragon.

“Ethics was the only subject I ever got a perfect score in, but today I’m going all out on an old man. Get up.”

No. Not a fire dragon.

Was he a Mad Dragon instead?

The sight of Jin Taekyung gripping Hwangbo Eom’s soot-and-blood-caked beard as though he had the old man by the hair jolted the thirty members of the Taeeul Sword Unit out of their stupor.

Who was that old man?

He was Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom, a senior of their sect and the Sect Leader’s senior martial brother.

“W-wait!”

“Martial Grandmaster!”

Voices erupted all at once, as if on cue.

Among them came one particularly loud, forceful shout.

“You bastard! Release Senior Martial Uncle this instant!”

Hwangcheon[1670], the Commander of the Taeeul Sword Unit and a second-generation disciple of the Zhongnan Sect, hurriedly drew his sword and stepped forward.

Shing. Clack.

“…!”

Hwangcheon’s eyes widened like saucers.

It had happened in the blink of an eye.

A cold blade had stopped at his throat. A yellow bamboo staff was pressed against his chest, while the sword he had drawn halfway from its scabbard had been caught on another blade and could go no farther.

The three martial artists who had subdued Hwangcheon, a Peak master of the Zhongnan Sect, in an instant spoke in turn.

“You’d better not draw that sword.”

“If you want a fight, the Yongbong Escort Bureau and I will be your opponents.”

[1670] Hwangcheon (□□) literally means “Yellow Springs,” a traditional term for the underworld.

“It’ll hurt quite a bit if you get hit by the Dog-Beating Staff Technique. I’ve only mastered it to five stars,[1671] though.”

Huashan’s Lone Crane Baek Museong, Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran, and the Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar, Gung Gibang.

And that was not all.

“Protect the Young Bureau Head!”

“This is troublesome. We’re almost finished, so we can’t let things end this way.”

Chief Escort Heo Jun and the cold-faced Song Ilseom, who had been muttering something incomprehensible, led the Yongbong Escort Bureau’s escorts in confronting the Zhongnan disciples.

“The branch leader commands you filthy Beggars’ Sect bastards! Show those dogs who are beneath even a yellow dog what a beggar’s cudgel feels like!”

“We’re beggars too. Why are you calling us bastards?”

“Good grief. It’s been ages since I got to really cut loose.”

“If any of us get hurt, it’s the branch leader’s responsibility. Don’t give us grief just because we can’t beg for a while.”

Heukgeol Beggar and the Beggars’ Sect disciples enthusiastically drew the cudgels hanging from their waists.

“You lot, don’t get involved and hurt yourselves for no reason. Write down every detail of what happens. We’ll be able to sell it for a high price later.”

“Um, are you planning to make an enemy of the Zhongnan Sect?”

“Hm? Why would I make an enemy of an important customer? I’m going to sell this to the Zhongnan Sect. Even if I jack up the price sky-high, they’ll have no choice but to buy it.”

“Ah! Of course!”

“Draw pictures too. Make them vivid enough to leap off the page.”

“Yes, ma’am!”

Hoping to make a fortune, Wolhwa and the Lower District Sect members began recording the scene before them in words and pictures without missing a single detail.

“Wow! I’ve never been in a situation like this before!”

“You bastards! Hyuk Mujin is here too—the Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad and the Captain’s right-hand man!”

Finally, even Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin, who had been watching from a safe distance, joined in.

As events took an unexpected turn, Hwangcheon’s face flushed with confusion and rage.

“W-what is the meaning of this? Everyone, stop this at once!”

[1671] Five stars means five-tenths mastery of the technique.

The answer came from somewhere else.

“What if we don’t want to stop?”

“…!”

Hwangcheon sucked in a breath.

Over the shoulders of the people blocking the Zhongnan Sect’s path, a pair of eyes filled with cold flames stared directly at him.

“I asked you. What are you going to do if I don’t want to stop?”

White steam billowed from Jin Taekyung’s sneering lips.

Perhaps it was because Hwangcheon had witnessed that unbelievable display of might. Merely meeting Jin Taekyung’s gaze and hearing that low voice in his ears was enough to make his breath catch.

His aura was truly overwhelming.

H-How can someone so young…?

Hwangcheon realized it once again.

To the young man who had defeated the Zhongnan Sect’s greatest master, age was nothing more than a number.

He’s a monster. That man is a monster.

And now that monster was looking directly at him.

How could the martial arts he had once taken such pride in feel so insignificant?

Hwangcheon swallowed dryly again and again as Jin Taekyung’s aura pressed down on him.

That was when—

“Junior Brother, withdraw. Everyone else, sheathe your swords.”

A calm voice sounded as a man stepped in front of him.

Hwangcheon’s eyes widened at the familiar back.

“Senior Brother Hyuk…!”

Zhongnan One Dragon Hyuk Sopyung.

He had been called the future of the Zhongnan Sect, and even now, despite his indulgence in wine and women, he had not lost his reputation as the sect’s greatest young prodigy.

Standing before Hwangcheon, he stared at Jin Taekyung with firm eyes.

Though dozens of weapons were pointed at him, his voice did not waver in the slightest.

“Please end this pointless fight.”

“Pointless? End it?”

A short, breathy laugh escaped Jin Taekyung’s lips.

“Even if you started it, I’m the one who decides how it ends.”

“I know. That is why I’m asking.”

“Asking? Just because you have a mouth doesn’t mean you can say whatever you want. Keep running it and someone might put a hole through it.”

“The outcome is already clear. I ask you to show the mercy of the strong.”

The Zhongnan disciples’ eyes widened—not at his surprisingly courteous manner or voice, but at the meaning of his words.

Hwangcheon, who had remained silent behind Hyuk Sopyung, raised his head and shouted.

“Senior Brother! The mercy of the strong? Those words dishonor Senior Martial Uncle and the Great Zhongnan Sect—”

“Junior Brother.”

“Y-yes?”

Hyuk Sopyung cut him off in a gentle voice.

But his next words were as sharp as a drawn blade.

“Will you shut that mouth of yours?”

“…Senior Brother?”

Not only Hwangcheon, but all thirty members of the Taeeul Sword Unit stared at Hyuk Sopyung with blank expressions.

Under the stunned gazes of all his junior disciples, Hyuk Sopyung slowly began to speak.

“Anyone who wasn’t blind would have seen it. Anyone who wasn’t deaf would have heard it—how all of this began.”

“…”

“We plotted in the shadows to swallow the Yongbong Escort Bureau whole. That is not the conduct of a great and prestigious sect. Therefore, our sect has already lost its dignity.”

His voice was low, and his expression was twisted with pain. But Hyuk Sopyung did not stop.

“Worse, even in the face of such clear evidence, we refused to admit our wrongdoing, harbored murderous intent, and swung our swords. That severed the last shred of trust our sect still possessed. And yet which one of us dares speak of reputation? Me, who forgot my duty and wallowed in wine and women? Or you, who refuse to admit your mistakes and cling only to your pride?”

Hwangcheon lowered his head.

He was not the only one. All thirty Zhongnan disciples fell silent, gripping the scabbards at their waists as if they meant to crush them.

They were ashamed because everything Hyuk Sopyung had said was true. And as the pride they had held in their sect crumbled, they felt hollow and humiliated.

No one spoke, but everyone around them could feel those emotions.

“At least today… we were not the Great Zhongnan Sect.”

With those final words, Hyuk Sopyung looked at his junior disciples with eyes filled with regret, then turned around.

He gave a deep fist-and-palm salute to the one man who had silently waited for him to finish.

“This Zhongnan disciple, Hyuk Sopyung, humbly asks this of you. We deeply regret and apologize for the wrongs our sect has committed. Please show mercy just this once and spare him.”

His manner was exceedingly respectful, as though he were addressing a revered master of the previous generation.

And yet the person receiving his salute was a barely grown young man.

After staring silently at the bowed Hyuk Sopyung for a moment, Jin Taekyung opened his mouth.

“It leaves a bad taste in my mouth to keep an old bastard like this alive… but fine. I’ll let him off this once.”

Before Hyuk Sopyung could even raise his head, Jin Taekyung continued brightly.

“After I hit him one more time.”

Craack!

The inside of Tengwang Pavilion was beyond ruined.

The roof had collapsed completely, and all the furnishings had been reduced to rubble and dust by the battle between Hwangbo Eom and me. Cold wind and the murmuring of onlookers drifted in through the collapsed walls.

“My heavens, Tengwang Pavilion…”

“What on earth happened? Does anyone know?”

“I don’t know the details either. But from what I’ve heard, about one shichen[1672] ago, Taeeul Merciless Sword of the Zhongnan Sect led his disciples…”

Xi’an was the center of Shaanxi Province. No matter how far out of the way Tengwang Pavilion was, it could not escape the people’s attention.

And the commoners who had gathered out of equal parts curiosity and concern found themselves facing dozens of sharp martial artists’ gazes.

“That’s far enough.”

“This is a matter of the martial world. Don’t get involved. Go back!”

Dozens of armed martial artists formed a human wall to block their approach. The commoners hesitated, then slowly backed away.

I clicked my tongue as I watched the Zhongnan disciples struggling desperately to keep the scene inside from being exposed.

[1672] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"Look at you trying so hard."

The Great Zhongnan Sect's reputation was already shot to hell, yet they were still fighting to preserve even a shred of it.

It was both pitiful and idiotic.

I dropped into a wooden chair with a broken back and spoke.

"Well, unpleasant things happened, but we still have to finish what needs finishing. Let's find some common ground through dialogue instead of barbaric violence."

"…"

"…"

Oof. Those stares were sharp.

I ignored the gazes raining down on me from every direction and smiled at one person.

"So, Great Hero Hwangbo, what do you think?"

Hwangbo Eom answered immediately.

Or rather, he groaned.

"Hrrgh… hrrrgh…"

Both of his arms were broken, and one leg was fractured. On top of that, he had suffered an Internal Injury that would require at least a year of recovery, while his nose and teeth had been smashed to pieces.

A sobbing groan escaped from his slightly open mouth, accompanied by the wet rattle of blood and phlegm.

"Hrrrgh…"

I grabbed Hwangbo Eom by the wrist.

Resisting the urge to break it, I sent a small amount of internal energy into him. A little color returned to his pale face.

"Patient? Sir, wake up. It's time for your injection—no, your negotiation."

"Hrrgh… Jin Taekyung. You…"

"That catchphrase went out of fashion fifty years ago."

"You bastard. Do you really think our sect will let you get away with this…?"

"Hm."

What do I do? He still doesn't seem to have come to his senses.

I scratched the back of my head, then whipped my hand out like lightning.

Smack!

"Guh!"

Hwangbo Eom's eyes rolled back from the slap.

As he trembled all over and began to slide out of the chair, Hyuk Sopyung caught him and sighed.

"Whew."

"It's not my fault. He keeps earning these beatings. He's practically begging me to kill him. What else am I supposed to do?"

"Even so, restrain yourself. Any more than this could endanger his life."

"You've had a rough time too. Judging by his personality, I can't imagine he treated you particularly well either. Am I wrong?"

"…What kind of person he was to me is irrelevant. He is my Master's senior martial brother and a disciple of our sect."

The complicated expression on Hyuk Sopyung's face suggested that there was some story between them.

He seems surprisingly decent now… Was that why he got drunk and caused all that trouble?

The question crossed my mind for an instant, but I had no intention of asking.

I wasn't particularly curious, either.

There was something more important to deal with now.

"All right, then. Let's negotiate. Young Lady Ju, are you ready?"

"Pardon? Y-yes, yes."

"You may state your demands."

What on earth happened here? Is this a dream?

Still looking as though she could not quite believe what was happening, Ju Hwaran rubbed her flushed cheek and began to speak.

"As compensation for this incident, the Yongbong Escort Bureau demands that the Zhongnan Sect void the contract and pay the contractual penalty—"

Hwangbo Eom's hoarse voice cut her off.

"We refuse. Our sect will not pay any compensation."

I knew it.

I gave the rigid Ju Hwaran a look.

"Young Lady Ju, wait a moment."

"Yes?"

"It'll only take a second."

Without hesitation, I slapped Hwangbo Eom across the face.

Smack!

"Guh!"

"Senior Martial Uncle!"

"I'll ask again. Are you paying compensation or not?"

Hwangbo Eom glared at me with burning eyes.

"Our sect will… not pay any compen—"

Smack!

“Guh! No compensation whatso—”
Smack!
“Guhhh! Our sect will pay any compensation!”
“Okay, compensation! Okay! Thank you!”
Negotiation sure was easy.

Chapter 326

The negotiations went smoothly.

“To begin with, looking only at the year before last, the Yongbong Escort Bureau suffered losses amounting to twenty-five thousand silver nyang because of the Zhongnan Sect’s schemes. Do you acknowledge that?”

“Twenty-five thousand silver nyang? What nonsense! This old man absolutely does not acknow—”

“Ha. This old bastard’s starting again.”

Smack!

“Guh! I acknowledge it! I acknowledge it!”

Of course, there were times when things did not go smoothly. But all that mattered was making them go smoothly.

The Beggars’ Sect organized the mountain of information they had gathered, and the Lower District Sect used it to calculate the losses on their abacuses.

“Let’s see. The contract cancellation with the Nakcheon Merchant Guild on the seventeenth day of the first month last year. The Zhongnan Sect was involved in this one, too.”

“How much were the damages?”

“Six hundred and thirty-two silver nyang.”

I had been quietly listening to the Beggars’ Sect disciple and Lower District Sect member talk when I suddenly spoke up.

“Seven hundred nyang.”

“Pardon?”

“Seven hundred nyang.”

“…Yes.”

The middle-aged Lower District Sect member, clearly a veteran of the banking trade, hastily crossed out the character for six and changed it to seven.

As I watched them work, I suddenly picked up one of the bamboo slips that had been set aside.

“What’s this?”

“Ah, that happened on the sixth day of the fifth month last year…”

“Skip the date. How much were the damages?”

“Nine hundred and twenty-six silver nyang.”

“Nine hundred and what?”

The Lower District Sect member quickly corrected himself when he saw my expression.

“One thousand nyang.”

“One thousand nyang? They really helped themselves, didn’t they? Is there anything they didn’t have a hand in?”

Two silver nyang was enough to cover a family of four’s living expenses for a month. The gap between rich and poor might have been severe, but one thousand silver nyang was enough for an ordinary commoner’s family to live in luxury for three generations.

As I marveled at the sum, the Lower District Sect member spoke up.

“Um, Young Hero Jin. That incident was not caused by the Zhongnan Sect.”

“It wasn’t? Then why is it here?”

“Well, you see, Young Master Jin…”

A long, slender finger poked my forearm. It belonged to Wolhwa, who had been standing behind me this entire time, giving off a strange fragrance.

“We brought every piece of information that seemed even slightly suspicious. When we compared everyone’s records, quite a few turned out not to have been Zhongnan’s doing. Young Lady Ju, the Young Bureau Head, would know that well.”

“Oh, really?”

Ju Hwaran was already examining the bamboo slip. After quickly scanning its contents, she nodded.

“That’s right. I remember this one clearly because the loss was so great. This escort mission failed because of a mistake on our side. Isn’t that right, Uncle Heo?”

Under everyone’s gaze, Chief Escort Heo Jun cleared his throat before answering.

“That’s correct. I personally took charge of the escort, and Chief Escort Song here accompanied me. Unfortunately, several misfortunes happened at once, and we failed to meet the deadline. In the end, we had to pay a contractual penalty of one thousand silver nyang.”

His face was filled with shame.

But I did not miss the suspicious look Heo Jun shot at Song Ilseom when he discreetly turned his head.

Nor did I miss Song Ilseom, standing far away with his back against the wall as though he had nothing whatsoever to do with the matter.

“Hmm.”

“What is it, Young Master Jin? Is something wrong?”

“No. Let’s move on.”

“All right, then. We’ll set this one aside separately.”

At that moment, someone’s hand blocked Wolhwa’s pale, slender fingers as they reached for the bamboo slip.

It was not a woman’s hand, but the rough hand of a martial artist.

Its owner was Ju Hwaran.

“Wait a moment.”

"Yes, Young Lady?"

"I've thought it over carefully, and I think this was probably the Zhongnan Sect's doing after all."

"…What?"

"…Huh?"

Everyone stared at her in confusion, but Ju Hwaran paid them no attention. She picked up the bamboo slip and held it out to the Lower District Sect member calculating the damages.

"Add this one, too."

"Y-Young Lady Ju."

I feel like I've seen this scene somewhere before.

The Lower District Sect member glanced between Wolhwa and me, squeezed his eyes shut, and moved his brush.

With just a few strokes, Ju Hwaran added the hefty sum of one thousand silver nyang. Then she picked up another bamboo slip.

"All right, shall we take another look at the others?"

"…"

"…"

"This one, too. And that one. Oh, hand me the one over in the corner. Yes, that one."

Ju Hwaran examined the bamboo slips and checked the amounts with lightning speed. Every time she did, the damages multiplied like rabbits.

The calculations in her head were precise, and her swindling was audacious.

"This part seems suspicious, too."

"Um, that was determined to have been a mistake by Chief Escort Heo Jun."

"No. It was the Zhongnan Sect's doing. Add it."

"Th-then we'll add another one hundred and fifty silver nyang…"

I let out a quiet laugh and spoke up.

"Two hundred silver nyang."

"Pardon?"

"Let's make it two hundred nyang."

Ju Hwaran shook her head.

"Three hundred nyang."

"…"

"…"

She went and doubled it. Talk about bold.

Hwangbo Eom, who had already half resigned himself to his fate, cried out in a blood-choked voice.

“I-I’ve never seen a pair of highway robbers like you!”

A pair of highway robbers?

Hwangbo Eom seemed intent on eating food set out for the dead starting tonight.

I was just about to begin preparing his funeral rites when—

“Did you just call us highway robbers?”

Ju Hwaran stared at Hwangbo Eom with an icy expression I had never seen on her before.

“Our Yongbong Escort Bureau is demanding what we are rightfully owed. If you refuse even that… then I will let the whole world know who the real highway robber is.”

“How dare you…”

“If every one of these facts is brought to light, will the disciples of the Zhongnan Sect still be able to show their faces in public?”

Ju Hwaran had been forced to lead the Yongbong Escort Bureau before she had even turned twenty, after her father collapsed from qi deviation.

She had lost so much to the Zhongnan Sect’s schemes, and her grief for those she had been forced to send off had sunk deep into her heart.

“Escort Captain Seok Domin, escorts Gil Wangjun, Hong Seokjeong, and Noh Dusam, and caravan porter Seok Sam…”

She recited the names of people I did not know in a trembling voice, then glared at Hwangbo Eom with tear-filled eyes.

“Thirty-three people in all lost their lives during this escort mission. Every one of them was family to the Yongbong Escort Bureau. Even when the bureau’s finances deteriorated so badly that we could no longer pay them properly, they stayed with us until the very end.”

They had not shared blood, but they had been like family.

Just as I had lost my former teammates, Ju Hwaran had lost people precious to her—people who had believed in her and followed her.

“Do not expect us to make any concessions. And neither I nor anyone else in the Yongbong Escort Bureau will ever forget this.”

“…!”

“Do you have anything else to say, Great Hero Hwangbo of the Great Zhongnan Sect?”

His tightly clenched fist trembled. Hwangbo Eom closed his eyes instead of answering.

Hyuk Sopyung stepped forward and gave Ju Hwaran a martial salute on his behalf.

“On behalf of our sect, I offer you our apologies, Young Lady Ju.”

“Please call me Young Bureau Head. And I will not accept an apology that consists only of words.”

At her blade-sharp reply, Hyuk Sopyung sighed.

“That goes without saying. I will immediately report this to my Master and the other Elders, who are still unaware of what happened.”

“I sincerely hope they were unaware.”

I did not know what sort of person the Zhongnan Sect Leader, Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, was.

But the former Sect Leader, whom Jeok Cheongang had described as “quite the Daoist,” had personally named him as his successor. I could only hope that meant he was someone who could be reasoned with.

The Yongbong Escort Bureau’s situation is one thing, and my own situation is another.

As the old saying goes, a crayfish sides with a crab, and an arm bends inward.

I had killed too many enemies to count, but Hwangbo Eom was not merely one martial artist.

The name Taeeul Merciless Sword represented the Zhongnan Sect, and on a personal level, he was also the Sect Leader’s Senior Brother.

I could eliminate him if I wanted to… but what comes after that is the problem.

The Zhongnan Sect was powerful enough to belong to the Nine Sects and One Gang.

If I had cut off Hwangbo Eom’s head, would they have simply stood by and watched?

Hyuk Sopyung, who had tried to stop me, and everyone else here must have guessed the same thing deep down: that I would not kill Hwangbo Eom.

Should I be satisfied with leaving him half-crippled?

It left a bitter taste in my mouth, but there was nothing I could do.

Hwangbo Eom would need at least a year of recuperation to recover from the injuries he had suffered today.

The important thing was that he was still alive—and by the time he recovered, I would be even stronger.

Since they were kind enough to shit all over themselves first, things became much easier.

Hwangbo Eom had made two critical mistakes. The first was drawing his sword. The second was ordering the Taeeul Sword Unit to seal off the pavilion.

Drawing his sword was one thing, but the second mistake had been fatal.

Because it dragged not only the Beggars’ Sect and the Lower District Sect into this, but Huashan as well.

The Zhongnan Sect's position would become even more precarious because of this incident—not only in the Murim, but financially as well.

The final number written on the bamboo slip after all the calculations were complete proved it.

"For the material and human losses suffered by our bureau, along with the enormous contractual penalty we would have owed your sect if this escort mission had failed… the total comes to four hundred thousand silver nyang. The Zhongnan Sect's finances should be able to handle that much, shouldn't they?"

Ju Hwaran's voice was calm, but the same could not be said of the people listening to her.

Gung Gibang dropped the bamboo staff he had been holding in shock, while Wolhwa marveled at the sum and whispered to me.

"Young Lady Ju—no, the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau—is something else, isn't she?"

"How large an amount is four hundred thousand silver nyang?"

"Well, if I told you that the annual budget of a prestigious major sect belonging to the Nine Sects and One Gang was just under one hundred thousand silver nyang, would that give you a rough idea?"

"…Huh."

"Young Master, you just don't know enough about it. If they paid that much all at once, they'd have to tear out half of the Zhongnan Sect's foundations."

In modern terms, would that be several trillion won?[1673] Thinking of it that way made the sum feel more tangible.

I was briefly rendered speechless by the astronomical amount when a gentle voice slipped into my ear.

"Not bad. She's beautiful enough to topple kingdoms, she's intelligent, and she has backbone. Our Young Master is going to have his work cut out for him."

"Pardon?"

"Hmm? What is it?"

"No, I'm sure you just said…"

"Did I? When?"

What was that? I feel like I just heard something awfully strange.

It was just as I was giving Wolhwa a suspicious look that Ju Hwaran's powerful voice rang out.

"Great Hero Hwangbo, please stamp your handprint yourself as proof."

We had already reached the final stage.

Hwangbo Eom was visibly furious, but he had no options left.

[1673] Several trillion won is roughly 3–9 trillion won, or about $2.1–6.4 billion and €1.9–5.8 billion.

As though he intended to curse every person in the room until the day he died, he took each of them in one by one with his eyes. Then he pressed his bloodied palm to the bamboo slip as a seal.

“Is that enough now?”

“That is sufficient. From this moment on, no contract exists between the Yongbong Escort Bureau and the Zhongnan Sect aside from the compensation payment.”

Ju Hwaran then gave a deep martial salute.

“I will not see you out. Return safely to your main compound. I hope we never have cause to meet again.”

“You…!”

Hwangbo Eom tried to shake off the hands of the Zhongnan disciples supporting him, but even that was no longer easy.

After coughing several times, each cough wet with blood, the last person he glared at was me.

“I have one question.”

“You can ask, but think before you open your mouth. Otherwise, you’ll be buried right there.”

Hwangbo Eom shuddered once before speaking.

“Did you truly… truly cross the wall?”

“Oh, so that’s what you were so curious about.”

“What I saw was that your Force was not yet complete. Then how…”

“My Master once told me that people see only as much as they can see, and believe only what they want to believe.”

“What does that…”

“Is it because you’re so old? You can’t seem to grasp the point. Think whatever you want about my realm. But…”

I could understand why he had his doubts.

But what could I do? In both reality and the Murim, I was the kind of existence that could be summed up in three words: beyond common sense.

That was the System, and that was who I was.

I gazed steadily at Hwangbo Eom and continued.

“Let’s remember two things. You’re weaker than me, and I’m stronger than you. And this place is… the Murim.”

Might Makes Right. The strong devour the weak.

The ground beneath my feet was the Murim, and I was a martial artist standing upon it. Hwangbo Eom, who had lived as a martial artist for eighty years, understood the meaning of my words better than anyone.

“The Murim. You said the Murim.”

His mutter sounded almost like a sigh. A brief, hollow laugh escaped him, and his face turned utterly cold.

"We'll meet again. We will!"

"I'll come pay my respects at your funeral next time. I promise!"

Half a shichen[1674] ago, he might have ground his teeth at me, but he had no teeth left for that now.

Hwangbo Eom turned away, radiating cold fury, and shook off the disciples' hands as he shouted.

"Let go! I'll walk on my own!"

Though staggering from his serious injuries, Hwangbo Eom forced himself to walk away. Hyuk Sopyung bowed his head heavily before departing, while the Zhongnan disciples hurried after him.

As I watched their retreating backs, one word suddenly came to mind.

Gratitude and grudges.[1675]

One of the great gears that drove the Murim.

I did not know what consequences today's events would bring in the future. But I did not regret it. I was already at odds with the Zhongnan Sect, and ignoring an obvious scheme would have left a bad taste in my mouth.

Pests have to be exterminated before they grow any bigger.

Pest control. That was all.

Just as I reached that conclusion with a lightened heart, another thought suddenly crossed my mind.

Oh, right.

There was still one left. A pest I absolutely had to catch.

A remarkable pest, too—the kind that had swapped Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng for Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng.

And I had not been the one who drew the sword to exterminate it.

Shing.

A supple flexible sword slid into view. Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran's deep-red lips parted, and a toneless voice flowed from them.

"Now there is only one last matter left. Isn't that right?"

One person was reflected in her dark, gleaming eyes.

[1674] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[1675] Gratitude and grudges are moral debts that must be repaid.

Chapter 327

“We still have the most important matter left to discuss. Don’t you agree?”

Ju Hwaran stood with her sword lowered at her side, beautiful and cold.

A frost-sharp aura surged around her, directed at one person.

“Captain Song.”

Everyone followed Ju Hwaran’s gaze. At its end stood a man who appeared to be in his early thirties. He was fairly handsome, save for the fierce upward slant of his eyebrows.

Song Ilseom’s lips twisted, and a chilly voice emerged.

“Are you calling me?”

The people still inside the pavilion fell into exactly two groups.

The outsiders, who had no idea who Song Ilseom was, looked confused. The escorts of the Yongbong Escort Bureau had gone rigid.

Chief Escort Heo Jun was the first to step forward, faint anger showing on his face.

“You stand before the Young Bureau Head. Show some respect.”

“I’ve shown enough respect. But you people have been saying the same thing for ten years.”

“How dare you…!”

“Then let me dare to ask you this: why does the Chief Escort lecturing me about respect call the Young Bureau Head by her name in front of everyone?”

“Th-that’s…”

“You needn’t answer. I don’t care what you call the Young Bureau Head. Just don’t demand courtesy from me.”

His tone and behavior were obnoxious, but Song Ilseom did have a point.

As I watched Heo Jun struggle for words, Wolhwa whispered to me.

“Young Master Jin, do you know that man well?”

“Who? Heo Jun? Or…”

“The young, handsome one, obviously. I already know who Chief Escort Heo is.”

“Then why are you asking me? You’re the Shaanxi Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect, of all people.”

“It’s nice that you think so highly of me, but what could a Branch Leader who’s been at her post for less than half a year possibly know? A disciple from a famous major sect would be one thing, but even I can’t keep track of every ordinary escort.”

“An ordinary escort… Do you know who he is?”

“Hmm. I know that one of the Dragon-Phoenix Three Escorts is young and has a nasty temper. That’s about it.”

Song Ilseom. Position: escort captain.

That was about all I knew of him too.

But I knew one thing Wolhwa did not.

Song Ilseom's strength.

He's quite a master. Stronger than the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

If there was one thing I had learned from going back and forth between the Murim and the modern world, it was that Level was never an absolute measure.

Some people had high Levels but were utterly useless, while others were stronger than people above their Level.

Song Ilseom was the real deal. I could tell just from his gait and the minute movements of his hands. He was a swordsman with extensive combat experience and exceptional martial arts.

How many people his age are that strong?

He might not be a disciple of some prestigious sect, but with that much skill, his name should have spread through the Murim long ago.

The saying about a needle in a bag existed for a reason. Exceptional talent was bound to reveal itself eventually.

Yet no one knew the needle was there. Not for ten whole years.

There was only one possible answer.

The needle had deliberately kept itself hidden—and done such a thorough job that even the people of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, who had spent years with him, had no idea how strong he truly was.

Well, well…

A thought suddenly crossed my mind. I could not be certain yet, but this was clearly someone I needed to watch carefully.

I'd like to step in right now, but…

This was a knot Ju Hwaran had to untangle herself.

While I finished preparing to intervene at any moment, Heo Jun recovered from his hesitation and pressed Song Ilseom even harder.

"Captain Song. No, Song Ilseom! Enough nonsense. Confess everything!"

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Fine. I'll ask you directly. Where did you hide the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng?"

"I know nothing about it."

"It's not too late. If you admit your crimes and tell us where the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng is, even now…"

"I said I don't know."

At Song Ilseom's answer, Heo Jun stared at him with eyes that had gone flat and cold.

"Is this really how you intend to play it?"

"I could say the same to you."

"I gave you one last chance for old times' sake… but I suppose it can't be helped."

Heo Jun raised his hand. More than twenty escorts spread out around Song Ilseom, sealing off every escape route.

The two middle-aged escort captains who appeared to be the other members of the Dragon-Phoenix Three Escorts joined Heo Jun in surrounding Song Ilseom from three sides.

The atmosphere pulled taut as a bowstring.

That was when Ju Hwaran, silent until now, abruptly spoke.

"Everyone, stand back."

"Hwaran, he won't confess willingly. We should subdue him first, then—"

"Wait, Uncle Heo. I have something to ask him."

Whoosh!

Her wrist turned. The flat of her flexible sword, curving like a snake, struck one of the bamboo slips piled on the table and sent it flying toward Song Ilseom.

"What is this?"

"There are quite a few interesting records here."

Song Ilseom checked what was written on the bamboo slip and muttered.

"This is…"

"That's right. Records of the escort missions you were responsible for over the past two years."

"You've collected only the failures."

"Why do you think the Lower District Sect and the Beggars' Sect gathered this information?"

"They must have suspected a connection to the Zhongnan Sect."

"You were responsible for fifteen escort missions over the past two years. Ten of them failed, and every failure forced the Yongbong Escort Bureau to pay a substantial contractual penalty."

Ten failures out of fifteen. His success rate was below fifty percent.

At that point, even Song Ilseom's parents would have suspected him, never mind the Beggars' Sect or the Lower District Sect.

Ju Hwaran continued calmly.

"That isn't all. The missions on which you served as assistant escort captain contain a remarkable number of suspicious details."

"I did my best every time, but I failed. That is the only answer I can give the Young Bureau Head."

"That isn't enough."

Whoosh! Clatter!

The flexible sword swept out again. More than twenty bamboo slips caught in its sword wind, sailed through the air, and scattered at Song Ilseom's feet.

"Are these all records connected to me? There certainly are a lot."

Clicking his tongue, he propped his sword beside him and began picking up the bamboo slips one by one to read.

"That bastard…"

Chief Escort Heo Jun looked ready to charge at the traitor then and there, but at a glance from Ju Hwaran, he had no choice but to let his sword droop.

They did not have to wait long.

"So that's how it was."

Song Ilseom set down the final bamboo slip and arched his fierce eyebrows.

"How did you know?"

"You were clever. Clever enough that each incident could be dismissed as a simple mistake."

"You figured it out from this alone? You're sharper than I expected. I thought you were merely a child, but… I underestimated you."

"That is truly unfortunate."

"What is?"

"Though not a single drop of blood connects us, I thought of you as family."

"Family? What weak-minded nonsense. Time changes even mountains and rivers. How could people be any different?"

At some point, Song Ilseom had gone from formal courtesy to openly talking down to her. Yet somehow, the change felt as natural as flowing water.

Like a man finally shedding a stifling set of clothes, he asked with an air of relief, "So what will you do now?"

"Punish the criminal."

"Children resemble their parents. But can the daughter of Junzi Sword[1676] truly do it?"

Ju Hwaran answered coldly.

"It is something I have to do, and I will do it."

Hissssss!

Her flexible sword, charged with internal energy, rose stiffly into the air. Ju Hwaran's hardened face was reflected in the transparent blade.

Her voice came low.

"No matter who it may be."

Whoosh!

[1676] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

She moved without warning, faster than anyone else in the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

Ju Hwaran might have only just entered the Peak realm, but she was still a Peak master. The essence of speed permeated both her sword arts and her movement technique.

Thrust!

The flexible sword streaked through the air like a ray of light and pierced its target precisely.

A wet sound rang out as it pierced flesh. Blood spurted into the air, followed by a scream from a single man.

“Gaaah!”

Ju Hwaran’s eyelids trembled as she watched him sink to his knees, scattering blood.

What followed was a question for one man.

A condemnation of the person she had never once doubted.

“Why did you make that choice, Uncle Heo?”

“H-Hwaran.”

The man raised his head.

Chief Escort Heo Jun’s face was deathly pale.

Whoosh!

Heo Jun’s hair stood on end, and a chill ran down his spine. But by the time he registered the faint sound of something cutting through the air, it was already too late.

Thud!

The blade piercing his flesh was cold as ice. The pain that followed burned like fire.

Chief Escort Heo Jun dropped to his knees with a scream.

Even then, only one thought circled through his blank, bleached-white mind.

It’s all gone wrong.

The unexpected appearance of Jin Taekyung had overturned the entire situation, but that had not necessarily been bad for Heo Jun.

Over the past two years, he had secretly skimmed off several thousand silver nyang[1677] by disguising his thefts as mistakes—sometimes small, sometimes audacious.

[1677] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of currency; here, the amount is denominated in silver.

He had already amassed an enormous fortune. If this incident led to the Yongbong Escort Bureau's revival, his authority as Chief Escort would only grow.

Best of all, he could escape the guilt of betraying those who trusted him.

Two birds with one stone.

But then…

Why now, of all times?!

If he cut Song Ilseom's throat, everything would be over.

Song Ilseom would have died branded as a traitor who had betrayed the Yongbong Escort Bureau and colluded with the Zhongnan Sect. The whole matter could have ended quietly, without any further trouble.

I even hid my identity so thoroughly from the Zhongnan Sect, just in case. How did they figure it out?

Pain.

And shock even greater than the pain froze Heo Jun where he knelt.

A low voice pierced his ears.

"Why did you make that choice, Uncle Heo?"

Heo Jun's bowed body trembled.

He knew that voice. How could he not?

It belonged to the girl he had watched over since she was a newborn.

She had been his sworn brother's treasured jewel, the one and only niece he had once regarded as more his own child than his biological children.

And…

She was also the person who had driven a sword through his shoulder.

"H-Hwaran."

Heo Jun slowly raised his head and met Ju Hwaran's downward gaze.

Unlike her calm voice, her eyes trembled with emotion. At the sight of them, a feeling he had momentarily forgotten reared its head.

Hope.

I can survive.

Heo Jun recognized the turmoil in Ju Hwaran's eyes at once.

She was torn between affection and betrayal. That was his only remaining escape.

"I was wrong. It was all my fault!"

"Uncle."

"Spare me. Please, I'm begging you!"

Heo Jun cried out desperately, heedless of the stunned escorts or the other people watching a trusted superior expose his betrayal.

His dignity? Their contempt?

A dead man could feel neither.

He would do anything if it meant surviving this place and seeing tomorrow's sun.

"Urgh. Hwaran…"

Heo Jun groaned in pain. Ju Hwaran's flexible sword had passed straight through his right shoulder, and the hand gripping its hilt trembled faintly.

"Then at least make an excuse. Tell me why you did it. Why you had no other choice."

If excuses would have raised his chances of survival even slightly, Heo Jun would already have offered every one he could invent.

But he knew Ju Hwaran too well. The fact that she had swung her sword meant she was already certain. A clumsy excuse now would only hasten his death.

He had to beg without reservation and appeal subtly to her emotions.

"It was all this foolish uncle's fault. I have nothing else to say."

Heo Jun let his head droop and reddened his eyes.

The effect was immediate. He felt the strength behind her sword weaken and continued.

"I am ashamed to admit that I once accepted a bribe. Then, after my hyung[1678] suddenly collapsed, the Zhongnan Sect used it as leverage to approach me, and I… I was afraid I would be cast out. I didn't want to leave the Escort Bureau I had devoted my entire life to, and I trusted the Zhongnan Sect when they promised they wouldn't hurt you."

"…"

"I intended to cooperate only once—just once—but by then, I had already stepped into a swamp I could never escape."

"Is all of that true?"

"How could I lie to you?"

Despite his claim, Heo Jun's entire story contained only one truth.

He had accepted a bribe.

He had been the one to approach the Zhongnan Sect after Junzi Sword collapsed, concealing his identity as he did so. Their secret relationship had continued for two years.

I only have to get through this moment. Just this moment!

Tears streamed down his face. They held no remorse—only terror of death and a desperate desire to survive.

"Please forgive me…!"

The onlookers shook their heads at his desperate plea. More than a few escorts turned away, unable to bear the sight.

Ju Hwaran did not.

[1678] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man. Heo Jun uses it for his sworn brother, Ju Hogun.

She stared at Heo Jun, biting her lip, then abruptly asked, “How did you steal the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng? I never let it out of my sight for even a moment.”

“Th-that…”

“Tell me the truth.”

“…I mixed a mind-clouding drug into the food. Everyone was exhausted, so a small dose was enough.”

The mind-clouding drug was a narcotic that clouded the mind and induced sleep. Its effects had been undeniable.

Even Ju Hwaran, a Peak master, had fallen into a deep sleep, mistaking the drug’s effects for the exhaustion of the journey.

“So that was why you were outside my room that night.”

“I had to conceal my presence even as I left. That bastard—no, Captain Song—remained awake until dawn despite taking the drug.”

Song Ilseom, leaning against the wall with his arms folded, muttered expressionlessly.

“So that was a mind-clouding drug. No wonder I felt unusually tired that day. Use something better next time—assuming you have a next time.”

What a goddamn bastard.

Heo Jun barely swallowed the curse rising to his lips and looked at Ju Hwaran.

“Hwangbo Eom, that old man, threatened me. He said that unless I switched the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, he would kill me and my family and wipe out the Yongbong Escort Bureau. I only wanted to protect everyone!”

“Then you made the wrong choice.”

“You’re right. I even went to my hyung’s[1679] sickbed once and confessed everything in tears. But… but I couldn’t undo my mistake.”

“Your mistake?”

Ju Hwaran’s eyes trembled at the mention of her father, but only for an instant.

Then she gave a small shake of her head.

“No. You’re wrong. It wasn’t a mistake. It was a choice, Uncle.”

“Hwaran…!”

“My father often told me that every choice carries responsibility. Though he failed to make the family business he inherited prosper, he never once regretted the choices he made.”

Heo Jun suddenly realized that the conflict and uncertainty he had seen in Ju Hwaran’s eyes were fading.

It can’t be.

No.

[1679] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man. Heo Jun uses it for his sworn brother, Ju Hogun.

It could not be.

This could not be happening!

Tears and cold sweat streamed down Heo Jun’s cheeks.

He desperately raised his voice.

“Give me one chance! Just one last chance! I’m your father’s one and only sworn younger brother, and your uncle, aren’t I? Hwaran, for the sake of the bond we’ve shared, please!”

“The bond we’ve shared, you say?”

“Yes! I shared thirty years of hardship and joy with my hyung.[1680] If your father were here—if it were him—he would not take my life so easily!”

“Uncle Heo. No—Chief Escort Heo Jun.”

Heo Jun stopped pounding his head against the floor and looked up blankly.

His niece’s eyes met his.

They were eyes he had never seen before—cold and utterly devoid of hesitation.

“You’re right. If my father were here, he would have forgiven you. But…”

Her low voice continued toward the frozen Heo Jun.

“I am not Junzi Sword Ju Hogun. I am Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran.”

The next instant, silver sword light filled Heo Jun’s vision.

Swish! Slice!

[1680] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man. Heo Jun uses it for his sworn brother, Ju Hogun.

Chapter 328

"Guh… ghk."

Blood gushed from Heo Jun's slashed throat.

He thrashed and clutched at his neck, but it was already too late.

Ju Hwaran's single sword strike had been fast and precise. It had accomplished its purpose without a single mistake.

"Grrk…"

It was the death rattle of a dying man.

What had he wanted to say? *This is unfair? Spare me? Or perhaps, I'll curse you even in death?*

Heo Jun's lips, which had been opening and closing as blood rattled in his throat, suddenly froze.

The strength drained from his flailing limbs. His eyes, fixed on Ju Hwaran and clouded with countless emotions, lost their light.

Haaa…

His final breath in this world dispersed into the air.

Heo Jun—the sworn brother of Junzi[1681] Sword Ju Hogun and the Chief Escort who had served the Yongbong Escort Bureau for thirty years—died just like that.

At the hands of the niece who had once followed him as though he were family.

"…Uncle Heo."

The words slipped quietly from Ju Hwaran's lips. From behind, she looked strangely desolate.

She gazed down at Heo Jun's lifeless body for a moment, then slowly turned around.

Her obsidian eyes passed over the escorts of the Yongbong Escort Bureau and settled on the outsiders.

One person at a time. Finally, she looked at me, then offered everyone a formal martial salute.

"I, Ju Hwaran, Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, have been discourteous before my seniors in the martial world."

Pain often made people mature. I hoped this ordeal had helped her grow.

It's a relief that she seems calmer than I expected, but…

There was an awkward edge to the air.

Just as I was thinking that, something pressed down hard on my foot.

I looked down and saw an ornate danghye.[1682]

[1681] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

[1682] *Danghye* are traditional Korean women's shoes, often decorated with embroidery.

As far as I knew, there was only one person here who would wear something like that.

When I gave her a questioning look, Wolhwa glanced pointedly to either side.

Only then did I notice everyone staring at me.

At some point, they had all split off to either side and were now looking straight at me.

At the end of the path they had opened stood Ju Hwaran, still holding her salute.

…What is this?

Was there something on my face?

As I stood there flustered, Wolhwa whispered so softly that I could barely hear her.

"Young Master Jin, say something."

"Pardon?"

"Young Lady Ju greeted us. You need to respond on everyone's behalf."

"Why do I have to do it?"

"Hurry. Young Lady Ju will grow old waiting."

"…"

Well, she had aged about ten seconds in the meantime.

I had no idea why I had to speak when Huashan's leading candidate for Sect Leader, the Beggar Prince, and the Lower District Sect's Shaanxi Branch Leader were all standing right there, but I gave an awkward bow anyway.

"There's no need to call it discourteous. And I'm not a senior in the martial world, so you can treat me casually."

"How could I do that?"

Ju Hwaran raised her head and spoke calmly.

"Great Hero Jin and the other seniors are Benefactors of the Yongbong Escort Bureau. Without your help, we would have suffered a terrible ordeal… and we would never have been able to punish the traitor."

A trace of bitterness crossed her face as she added those final words.

Perhaps she noticed it herself, because her voice grew firmer.

"I will repay the debt we owe you today without fail."

I couldn't exactly claim it had been nothing. The help provided by me and the other sects had certainly been substantial. From the perspective of Ju Hwaran and the Yongbong Escort Bureau, even a hundred bows wouldn't have been enough.

Still, being called Great Hero is a little much.

Even Young Hero made me cringe, and now the title had evolved to the next stage.

Feeling as though I ought to grow a beard, I changed the subject.

"Repay the others, not me. More importantly, what are you going to do now?"

"We'll recover the body first and return to the bureau. There's a lot to take care of."

"You must be incredibly busy."

Ju Hwaran was managing the bureau in place of her unconscious father.

Dealing with the aftermath of the long escort mission alone would fill her days, and after one outrageous incident after another, even ten bodies wouldn't be enough to handle everything.

Ju Hwaran nodded.

"Even so, we have enough time to host Great Hero Jin and his companions."

"You have enough time? That's a relief… Huh?"

"You and your companions are Benefactors who saved me and everyone under my care. I cannot send you away without offering you proper hospitality."

"Um, Young Lady Ju, the thing is…"

"Are you perhaps very busy?"

I was busy. Extremely busy.

Jeok Cheongang had a treatment window of six months at minimum and eight at most.

Within that time, I had to scour the vast land of Sichuan for the mysterious person known as the Divine Physician.

It took us a week to get from Henan to Shaanxi. Reaching Sichuan will take at least another week, no matter how fast we travel.

And that was assuming I used my movement technique to the fullest.

Everything about the Divine Physician was shrouded in mystery. No one could predict how long it would take to find him.

That was why spending even a single day in Xi'an had already made me anxious.

And it's already late in the day.

The sun had passed its zenith long ago. Our entanglement with the Zhongnan Sect had cost us a considerable amount of time, so I needed to start running as though my feet were on fire.

And yet…

"No, I'm not busy."

My mouth opened of its own accord, and that ridiculous answer slipped out.

What had just happened? That was the exact opposite of what I had meant to say.

As I stood there dazed, Ju Hwaran cautiously asked,

"Great Hero Jin, are you really all right? If you have something urgent to attend to, we can postpone it until later."

Thank you. Thank you so much for saying that first.

Sharp and perceptive as ever. She had scratched exactly where it itched, and I answered without hesitation.

"No matter how urgent it is, can't I share one meal with you?"

"Right…"

"I was already hungry after exerting myself so much. This works out perfectly. Let's go."

Am I a fucking idiot? Seriously?

I needed to go to Sichuan. Why the hell was I going to the Yongbong Escort Bureau?

But by the time I came to my senses, I had already hoisted the pack frame onto my back.

Just as I heaved an inward sigh, I noticed someone who had remained completely detached from everything going on around him.

When I stared at him, he spoke first.

"What? Do you have something to say?"

This was the first time casual speech from someone I had just met sounded so natural.

Since he had dropped the formalities first, that made things easier for me too.

"I was just wondering if you weren't coming."

"I have no reason to."

"Then make one."

"…?"

"I know you have plenty of time to spare, so let's have a conversation."

"A conversation?"

"Yeah. A conversation."

Song Ilseom raised an eyebrow at me, then pushed himself upright from where he had been leaning.

It was early spring. The blazing sun disappeared behind the western mountains less than two shichen[1683] after we arrived at the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

Oil lamps illuminated the reception room, where a magnificent feast had been laid out across the table. Cheongpung and Gung Gibang stared wide-eyed as they crammed food into their mouths.

"Mmph. Benefactor. This is delicious. Mmph-mmph-mmph."

"…Eat as much as you want. Preferably don't talk."

The food did look delicious.

At least until Cheongpung went out of his way to show me what was in his mouth.

[1683] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours (120 minutes).

“Gobble, gobble. This Escort Bureau sure knows how to cook. Young Bureau Head, could you give the extra food to the members of our sect as well?”

Gung Gibang really was a beggar to the bone.

As he continued his meat-centered massacre, Ju Hwaran nodded.

“Of course. Tell them they can come whenever they’re hungry.”

“Oh, whenever they’re hungry?”

“…Not quite that much.”

If every Beggars’ Sect disciple in Shaanxi Province descended on the place, all four hundred thousand silver nyang[1684] of the compensation would disappear into food costs.

Gung Gibang grinned, baring his yellow teeth.

“Don’t worry. I’ll make sure to explain it so you have nothing to worry about.”

Hyuk Mujin, who was at least eating normally, whispered,

“The way he says that makes me even more worried.”

“You said it.”

At this rate, the Yongbong Escort Bureau might go under because of the Beggars’ Sect instead of the Zhongnan Sect.

I was resolving to give him a warning when Ju Hwaran spoke to me.

“It’s a shame the others didn’t come.”

“Yeah. The food is good, too.”

The others in our group—Baek Museong, Heukgeol Beggar, and Wolhwa—had all declined the invitation.

I wasn’t sure why, but the two men might have changed their answers after Wolhwa gave them a long, pointed stare.

In any case…

“For someone who likes the food, you aren’t eating very much.”

“No, it’s delicious. Look. I’ve already finished two bowls of rice.”

“That’s strange. Why does it seem as though you’ve barely eaten?”

“It’s all relative. Look at them. They’re waging the Great Faction War against the food.”

Schlurp, schlurp!

Gobble, gobble!

Chomp, chomp, chomp!

Ju Hwaran nodded as though she had attained enlightenment.

“Ah.”

“Mujin and I are the normal ones. The person who’s actually eating very little is over there.”

[1684] A silver *nyang* is a historical silver currency unit; it is not Korean won.

Song Ilseom replied in his usual blunt tone.

“I’ve been saying this for ten years, but the food here is too salty. Spicy and salty dishes overstimulate the senses and weigh down the body.”

“That reminds me of someone. If she were here, she’d beat you to death with a ladle.”

“Who are you talking about?”

“Someone I know. One hit from her and you’ll scream whether you mean to or not. She’s beaten the hell out of me over the years, and strangely enough, I’ve never managed to dodge her once.”

“Great Hero Jin, is that true?”

“You?”

Ju Hwaran asked back in surprise, and Song Ilseom’s eyes flashed.

“If even you, the man who defeated the Taeeul Merciless Sword, say so… she must be an extraordinary master indeed. Can you tell me her name and epithet?”

“Kim Jeonghee. Her epithet is Lady.”

“Hmm. I’ve never heard of her.”

Of course he hadn’t. She was my mother.

Without showing anything on my face, I continued in a solemn tone.

“In any case, she always said you had to eat all kinds of food without being picky if you wanted to grow big—no, strong.”

“Hmm.”

“So stop whining about the side dishes and fucking eat.”

Song Ilseom pondered this with a serious expression, then picked up his chopsticks and began eating the side dishes.

The more I watched him, the stranger his personality seemed.

He’s strange, but he doesn’t seem dangerous.

A few shichen[1685] earlier, I had briefly suspected Song Ilseom of being something very bad indeed.

It had been a reasonable suspicion. He was an exceptional Peak master who had concealed his strength for ten years, and I had already encountered a similar case in Shanxi Province.

Dark Heaven.

The Head Elder and the Five Gates of Shanxi had lain low for decades. Perhaps that was why Song Ilseom’s behavior had reminded me of them.

But the longer I spoke with him, the more my suspicion faded, leaving only curiosity behind.

What the hell is this guy?

[1685] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours (120 minutes).

His blunt manner of speaking and behavior. He seemed rough to the point of being crude, yet there was a peculiar air of refinement in his appearance and various other aspects of him.

Perhaps that was why his casual speech sounded so natural.

Well, this is something.

I stared at Song Ilseom.

He chewed the side dishes thoroughly, his face twisted into an exaggerated grimace. After swallowing, he spoke.

“That look again. What is it?”

“I was just thinking about your identity.”

“Are you that curious?”

“Yeah. Very.”

Talking with this guy was like driving down a wide-open highway. That was why it felt so comfortable.

Before long, everyone else—including Ju Hwaran—had pricked up their ears and fixed their eyes on Song Ilseom’s mouth.

Apparently displeased by the attention, he raised an eyebrow.

“There’s nothing special about it. I stayed at the Yongbong Escort Bureau because of a connection to the previous generation.”

“A connection to the previous generation?”

“To be precise, my father received a great kindness from them.”

Huh? Wait a second. That sounded familiar, but I couldn’t quite place it.

I turned and found Ju Hwaran staring wide-eyed at Song Ilseom.

This was clearly the first time she had heard the story in ten years.

“May I ask your father’s name?”

“Song Pyosan.”

“Song Pyosan… I’ve never heard that name.”

“That’s hardly surprising. It happened almost fifty years ago.”

Almost fifty years ago? Was he talking about the Great Faction War?

Before we could ask, Song Ilseom continued as though it were nothing important.

“The Guangdong Chen Family was a clan forgotten long ago. My grandmother was saved with the help of Escort King Ju Gongsan, but she feared the greedy martial artists and had her child carry on her surname. It was a wise decision.”

I felt completely blindsided. Ju Hwaran stared at Song Ilseom with trembling eyes.

“Then could you be…?”

Instead of answering, Song Ilseom drew a faded jade hairpin from his robes and held it out.

It was the only escort fee a young escort surnamed Ju had received from a heavily pregnant woman more than fifty years ago.

Chapter 329

When Song Ilseom's identity was revealed, everyone was astonished.

Hyuk Mujin had admired the Murim even before becoming part of the Taiyuan Jin Family, so of course he knew the stories about him. Even Cheongpung pretended to know him, claiming that the Sword Saint had told him about Song Ilseom.

"Mmph-mmph. Grandpa said the Escort King was a good man. Gulp. That's what he said."

"…I know. Just swallow before you talk. Please."

"Okay! Mmph-mmph."

If even Cheongpung knew the story, the other two went without saying.

Ju Hwaran, the Escort King's granddaughter, was staring at the jade hairpin with trembling eyes, while Gung Gibang was so excited that he sprayed the contents of his mouth in every direction.

"Th-the Guangdong Chen Family!"

Tududududuk!

Song Ilseom knocked away a dozen or so grains of rice with his chopsticks and replied.

"As I said, the Guangdong Chen Family ceased to exist long ago. By the way, can you do something about all that flying out of your mouth?"

"My Master also told me about the Escort King's Ten-Thousand-Mile Escorts. But to think the child from that story was you!"

"Did you listen with your nose? That child was my father. And stop spitting everywhere. It's disgusting."

Swish! Tududududuk!

Wow. He knocked away every single one.

After whipping his chopsticks through the air like lightning yet again, Song Ilseom asked me, "Is this beggar really the Successor Beggar of the Beggars' Sect?"

"He is, even if he doesn't look like it. Why?"

"A Rain of Ten Thousand Flowers keeps pouring from his mouth. I wondered if he might be a disciple of the Sichuan Tang Clan."

"Hmm. Probably not."

While we were talking, Ju Hwaran finally spoke, her gaze still fixed on the jade hairpin.

"My father told me about it. He said my grandfather wondered what had become of the Guangdong Chen Family until the very end, but he was never able to find them…"

"My grandmother carried that regret with her as well. She had to flee with my father, who was still a baby, without leaving so much as a letter."

"Why did they suddenly disappear?"

"Because it was dangerous. The Guangdong Chen Family's martial arts were all lost when the family estate burned to the ground, but apparently no one believed it."

"But if they were within the territory of the orthodox factions…"

"Greed does not discriminate between members of orthodox factions and practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts. Some of those seeking the Guangdong Chen Family's Peak martial arts were people even the Escort King's name couldn't deter."

A time of chaos.

Those words gave me some idea of what the mother and child must have endured back then.

In chaotic times, the rules binding people together crumble. Everyone gives in to their instincts, and morality inevitably fades.

The mother had fled to protect her child from the greed of others, without telling anyone.

"My grandmother was an ordinary woman who couldn't have stood against even a Third Rate swordsman, but she was wiser than ten Peak masters combined."

After a brief silence, Song Ilseom added, "Of course, even she couldn't escape birth, aging, sickness, and death."

"Then…"

"She died of an illness when I was ten. As she gave me this jade hairpin, she told me everything that had happened. It was an astonishing story—the first I had ever heard of it."

Despite his blunt demeanor, Song Ilseom was surprisingly good at telling a story.

The one thing I had been curious about was what had happened to his parents. But once I heard that he had wandered the streets after his grandmother's death, there was no need to ask.

Unfortunately, both of them had clearly died young.

As soon as one question disappeared, another took its place.

"Then how did you develop that level of skill? Didn't you say the Guangdong Chen Family's martial arts were lost as well?"

Song Ilseom's answer was simple.

"On the battlefield."

"Did you live as a wandering martial artist?"

"I had no talent for begging. More people beat me because they disliked my face and expression than tossed me an iron coin."

Gung Gibang, who had been listening quietly, nodded with deep sympathy.

“There’s a proper way to beg. The most important thing for a beggar is a face and expression that inspire pity, but when you’re as handsome as Song Ilseom or me, even earning a few coins is difficult. I went hungry plenty of days myself.”

Song Ilseom’s expression hardened.

“Successor Beggar, I find that remark deeply offensive. I’d appreciate it if you stopped insulting me.”

“Why? Did you ever see my face when I was young? I’m telling you, without the slightest exaggeration, I was handsome enough to make Song Yu weep.”[1686]

“Song Yu would weep?”

Song Ilseom stared intently at Gung Gibang’s face, which looked like something out of a Picasso masterpiece.

“With that face, he might. If you run into me at night, stay far away. If I suddenly came face-to-face with you, I might cut you by mistake.”

Looking as though he was debating whether to cut him down right then and there, Song Ilseom continued his story.

“In any case, I was hopeless at begging and couldn’t find any decent work. After going hungry for more than three days, the sky started turning yellow. I decided becoming a sword boy would be better than starving to death.”

“A sword boy? The kind who carries someone’s sword?”

“That’s right.”

“Isn’t that something rich people hire? They can’t be bothered carrying their own swords, so they make someone else do it.”

“Do you think rich people would hire some beggar brat who crawled in from who knows where?”

“Fair point.”

“Surprisingly, wandering martial artists hire the most sword boys. They make them handle every odd job imaginable, then use them as meat shields when things get dangerous.”

I thought it sounded like a sweet gig, but it turned out to be a part-time job straight out of the Hell Continent.[1687]

“It wasn’t a particularly comfortable or pleasant experience.”

Song Ilseom calmly recounted his past.

Most days, he waited on wandering martial artists while enduring constant abuse and violence. When arrows rained down, he went out to retrieve weapons.

When the wandering martial artist abandoned him and fled because he was too busy saving his own life, Song Ilseom experienced nothing short of hell.

[1686] Song Yu was an ancient Chinese poet celebrated for his beauty.

[1687] “Hell Continent” echoes a Korean expression for harsh living and working conditions in modern South Korea.

“I hid among piles of corpses for four days. When I barely made it out alive and went looking for the wandering martial artist, the first thing he did was search for the sword he had entrusted to me.”

“Wow. What a crazy bastard.”

“Fortunately, the two swords I was carrying were unharmed. Even while fleeing, I refused to let go of them.”

“…Wow. You really are a crazy bastard.”

“I wasn’t as crazy as he was. He started spouting nonsense about how he had originally entrusted me with three swords, then told me to get the hell out of there if I didn’t want to die like a dog. Of course, he didn’t give me a single coin for the year I had worked for him.”

Song Ilseom brushed back the hair that had fallen over his forehead and muttered, “That pissed me off.”

Naturally, instead of filing a complaint with the labor authorities, he chose a faster solution.

“There happened to be two swords. I picked one up. It was heavy.”

“You won.”

“I killed him.”

Song Ilseom casually corrected me as he twirled his chopsticks.

“It wasn’t difficult. I’d watched his martial arts every day, and they were predictable. I dodged ten times and stabbed once, as if we’d rehearsed the whole exchange. Then he fell.”

Gulp.

Hyuk Mujin swallowed nervously and asked,

“How old were you then?”

“Twelve? Thirteen? I don’t remember exactly, but it was around then.”

“Th-then your opponent…”

“He was a lousy Third Rate wandering martial artist. If he’d been First Rate, do you think I’d have been crazy enough to take him on?”

No, I think a kid who hadn’t even graduated from elementary school attacking a martial artist was already insane.

What was I doing at that age?

Who knew? I was probably running around picking my nose or something.

This guy’s a gifted bastard too.

Countless martial sects and families existed throughout the world.

If the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were the first tier, there naturally had to be a second tier.

According to something Jeok Cheongang had mentioned in passing, the Guangdong Chen Family had belonged to that second tier.

Blood will tell, huh?

To reach that level without any of his family's secret martial arts…

Just as I was marveling at the thought that Song Ilseom really was something special, Gung Gibang, who had been silent for a while, suddenly stared at him in shock.

"Could you be the Soul-Chasing Guest?"

"That's what they called me ten years ago. By the way, is your mouth a bottomless jar? How the hell are you still spitting out rice after all this time?"

"Hah. I never imagined the famous Soul-Chasing Guest would be a young man around my age."

The Soul-Chasing Guest. That was apparently Song Ilseom's former epithet.

He must have been almost as famous as he was skilled, because Ju Hwaran's eyes widened as well.

"You're the Soul-Chasing Guest who won a hundred life-and-death duels?"

"One hundred and two, to be exact. It's all hollow fame, so there's no need to make a fuss. There are already two people here younger and more impressive than me."

Cheongpung, who had somehow finished off most of the food, grinned.

"No, you're still amazing, Young Hero Song."

I nodded.

"Yeah, he's strong. Weaker than me, though."

"…Are you two making fun of me?"

Cheongpung slurped down something that looked like cinnamon punch and answered, "No teasin' you!"

"He says he isn't teasing you."

At my helpful translation, Song Ilseom's gaze shifted toward me.

"What about you?"

"I am teasing you."

"…Got any booze? I feel like having a drink for the first time in a while."

The meal, which had begun in the early evening, didn't end until close to midnight.

Ignoring the fine liquor, Song Ilseom had downed cup after cup of strong liquor and now had his head planted on the table. Ju Hwaran, who had been sipping hers, had flushed cheeks as well.

And then…

It really is time to go.

When I rose, Gung Gibang used his internal energy to purge the alcohol from his body, while Hyuk Mujin hoisted Cheongpung onto his back. Cheongpung was already completely wasted and snoring softly.

“We’ve imposed on you, Young Lady Ju.”

“You’re leaving already?”

“I’d like to stay longer, but I don’t think I can this time.”

“Is that so?”

Her drunken eyes curved like half-moons.

Her steps were light, almost as if she were dancing, and deep dimples showed in her cheeks. Apparently, drinking made her laugh.

“Would you like to take a walk?”

“Pardon?”

“Let’s go for a walk. The flowers in the garden have just bloomed.”

“Oh. Congratulations. They must be pretty.”

She burst out laughing.

Before I could ask what was so funny, Ju Hwaran giggled and stepped outside.

I followed her without thinking, then stopped short and turned around.

“You two aren’t coming?”

“…Is he even human?”

“Lower than a beggar. Beggarly bastard. Worse than a beggar.”

“What the hell? Why are you looking at me like that?”

“It’s how I feel.”

“That’s how I feel.”

“Come on. Young Lady Ju said the flowers have bloomed in the garden. We can look around together and leave right afterward. The timing will be perfect—”

The sighs of Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin cut me off.

The two men shook their heads with expressions of utter horror, then spoke in turn.

“I need to take a dump. Where’s the latrine?”

“Me too. We’ll take turns going back and forth, so take your time looking around.”

“…Uh. Sure.”

What’s wrong with those two? Do their stomachs hurt that badly? Their faces look downright demonic today.

I must be imagining the contempt and fury in their eyes.

I hurried outside and began walking through the garden beside Ju Hwaran, who was waiting for me.

“Great Hero Jin is… how should I put it? You’re a very interesting person.”

“Am I?”

"Yes. You can be a little exasperating sometimes, but… well, in a way, that's one of your strengths too."

"…?"

What is this? Is she insulting me indirectly?

At my bewildered expression, the smile on Ju Hwaran's lips deepened.

"I don't remember the last time I laughed out loud. It must have been more than half a year ago."

"Hmm? Didn't you laugh last time too? When we passed Black Stone Mountain?"

"Oh. Did I?"

"Maybe you just don't remember. That makes twice in three days."

"I wonder. Is that really it?"

Ju Hwaran murmured dreamily, then suddenly pointed at the sky.

"Great Hero Jin, do you see that?"

"Of course. It's a full moon."

"The moon is especially bright tonight."

"Did you know why the moon is bright, Young Lady Ju? It's because it reflects light from the sun."

"Pardon?"

"No, I'm serious. It's not some ridiculous story. It's a famous result of scientific research… No, I heard it from a scholar. Where was it? That's right, somewhere around the imperial palace."

Another quiet laugh slipped from her lips.

"No, it really is true…"

"All right. I'll believe you. By the way, Great Hero Jin."

"Yes?"

"This."

To me, still feeling wronged, Ju Hwaran suddenly held something out.

A solid, elongated wooden case. One I had already seen at the teahouse.

"Could this be…?"

"That's right. Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng."

"…"

"It's a small gift compared to what you've done for us, but would you accept it? It would put my heart at ease, at least a little."

I silently looked back and forth between Ju Hwaran and the wooden case.

Should I refuse? Should I accept it? Should I refuse…

After several rounds of agonizing, I finally nodded.

"I'll accept it gratefully. Thank you."

Ju Hwaran beamed.

Her smile was brighter than the moon hanging in the sky.

We walked for about fifteen minutes, chatting about nothing in particular, until the flowers lining both sides of the path gradually began to thin.

Ju Hwaran's steps slowed as well.

"Great Hero Jin."

"Yes, Young Lady Ju?"

"Do you think I can do well?"

Her sudden voice sounded raw and desolate.

Perhaps this was why she had drunk.

But there were days like that. Days when nothing could hold your emotions back. Moments when everything you had struggled to suppress finally surged over the brim.

"Do you really think I can do well?"

I spoke.

"It's okay if you can't."

"…"

It's okay. I understand how you feel. Stay strong.

Sometimes, every word of comfort sounded hollow. Of course she wasn't okay. Someone standing a step removed could never fully understand what the person suffering was going through, and being told to stay strong didn't suddenly give you strength.

I didn't offer Ju Hwaran some clumsy consolation today because she was already suffering enough.

"You're only human too, Young Lady Ju. It's okay if you don't do well. You don't have to force yourself to be strong."

She only had to keep going as she had, following the current wherever it carried her.

One step at a time, at her own pace rather than someone else's.

"Wouldn't that be enough?"

Ju Hwaran looked up at me, tears clinging to her eyes.

Then they curved like half-moons.

Thump!

I kicked off the ground.

The scenery receded, and the earth blurred past beneath me.

The voices of Ju Hwaran and the people of the Yongbong Escort Bureau gradually faded before cutting off entirely.

Only then did the two guys who had been watching me warily speak.
“Young Lady Ju’s eyes looked swollen earlier…”
“Do you think she cried? No. No way. She couldn’t have.”
They noticed that carefully even in the dark.
When I didn’t answer, Hyuk Mujin pointed at the bulge beneath my clothes.
“But what’s that?”
“Oh, this?”
I forgot to put it in my Inventory.
I let out a quiet laugh as someone’s lie came to mind.
“Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng.”
“Whaaat?”
“Huh?”

Chapter 330

Around midnight.

The four figures leaving the Yongbong Escort Bureau vanished in the blink of an eye.

The members of the bureau who had come to see them off shivered in the cold wind, but Ju Hwaran stood perfectly still.

As if someone might return if she waited just a little longer.

It was then that she heard a voice from the darkness.

“They’re gone.”

Startled by the voice’s soundless arrival, the escorts parted to either side. Ju Hwaran, however, remained composed.

“Yes. They’ve left.”

“Are you disappointed?”

“I’d be lying if I said I wasn’t.”

“It can’t be helped. Those who leave, leave. Those who stay, stay. That’s the way of things.”

“The way of things…”

Ju Hwaran murmured the words, then slowly turned around.

“Which are you, Captain Song?”

“Me?”

Song Ilseom gave a quiet laugh and conspicuously swung the travel pack slung over his shoulder.

“Which do you think?”

“Is that why you pretended to pass out drunk?”

“It’s been ten years. I’d say I’ve done my duty by now…but is that still not enough?”

“No.”

“…!”

“It isn’t enough. You still haven’t done your duty.”

Song Ilseom’s brow furrowed at Ju Hwaran’s unhesitating answer.

“Still not enough? Even after I protected the Yongbong Escort Bureau—and you—for ten years?”

“Can that compare to the debt of gratitude owed for my grandfather’s lifesaving deed?”

“You…!”

Song Ilseom raised his voice and stepped forward. The nearby escorts flinched and gripped their sword hilts.

They had not heard the hidden truth of his origins. To them, Song Ilseom was still someone to be wary of. The other two escort captains who made up the Dragon-Phoenix Three Escorts with him were openly hostile.

"Lower your voice. It'll be better for your health."

"We don't know what the Young Bureau Head thinks, but we're not convinced. No matter how we look at it, there's something suspicious about you."

The two escort captains blocked Song Ilseom's path with grim expressions.

"Enough. Step aside."

At Ju Hwaran's calm voice, the two escort captains stammered.

"Y-Young Bureau Head."

"But this man hasn't completely cleared himself of suspicion yet—!"

"I said step aside. I have something important to discuss with him. Everyone return to your posts and take care of the remaining work."

"Hmm…"

"Y-yes, ma'am."

Their mouths worked as if they still had more to say, but the two escort captains finally nodded and slowly withdrew with the other escorts.

Song Ilseom watched them leave, then clicked his tongue at Ju Hwaran.

"I can't tell whether they're loyal or stupid. After all that's happened, they still can't tell friend from foe."

"Your premise is wrong."

"What?"

"They're neither loyal nor stupid, despite what you think."

A question flashed through Song Ilseom's mind.

Could it be?

The insight came in an instant.

He was a born fighter and a martial artist through and through, but that did not mean he was stupid.

Once he grasped the situation, Song Ilseom muttered, "What a damned mess."

Ju Hwaran nodded.

"They deliberately sabotaged escort missions and contracts, siphoned off funds amid the confusion, and carefully doctored the ledgers. There's no way Uncle Heo did all of that alone."

"Just how far does this conspiracy reach?"

"We'll have to determine the exact number and identities from here on…but at the very least, those two must be included."

Ju Hwaran's gaze swept over the retreating backs of the two escort captains before settling on Song Ilseom.

"I'm going to root them out completely."

“Why didn’t you reveal it right there after the Chief Escort was killed?”

“The confusion would only have grown worse. Besides, if I can’t accomplish even this with my own strength, I have no right to become the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau.”

“Are you confident?”

Ju Hwaran stared silently at Song Ilseom.

“How about putting away that travel pack and taking it out again a year from now?”

“You want to use me to root them out?”

“Captain Song, right now I need a blade sharp enough to cut down anyone. As it happens, the perfect person is standing right in front of me.”

“I refuse. And stop calling me Captain.”

“Then how about hiring the Soul-Chasing Guest?”

“What?”

Ju Hwaran shrugged.

“The renowned Soul-Chasing Guest won’t come cheap…but given our past connection, perhaps you’ll offer me a discount?”

“So I’m supposed to repay that lifesaving debt this way?”

“If that were my intention, I would have asked for something much greater.”

“A moment ago, you said I still hadn’t done my duty in return for the Escort King’s lifesaving grace.”

“That was because too many people were watching. My grandfather said it himself. He was merely one person saving another.”

“Ha!”

Song Ilseom could no longer hold back his laughter.

He remembered what Junzi Sword[1688] Ju Hogun had said ten years ago to the young man who had come to him carrying a faded jade hairpin.

“Though a generation passed before we met, you came to find us in the end. That is enough. Don’t let the ties of the previous generation bind you. Live your own life.”

“Pardon?”

“My father told me that what he had done was simply save another person. I feel the same way. And…thank you for growing into such a fine young man.”

It had been a shock.

From childhood onward, Song Ilseom’s life had been one continuous struggle. His parents had died young, and when his only source of support—his grandmother—passed away as well, he had been forced to make his way alone, without anyone’s help.

[1688] *Junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

He had stolen weapons from piles of corpses, cut down wandering martial artists who tried to rob him of his rightful pay, and proven himself through countless life-and-death duels.

I thought he would ask me for something.

To Song Ilseom, who had lived as a wandering martial artist, that was only natural.

If Ju Hogun had wanted someone eliminated, Song Ilseom would have willingly done it. It would have left a bad taste in his mouth, but killing was what he had always done.

It would have been just one more among the countless requests he had completed.

But Ju Hogun had been different.

He was the first "adult" Song Ilseom had met since becoming an orphan with no one in the world.

Perhaps that was why the words had slipped out before he could think.

"Ten years."

"Hmm?"

"I'll leave after ten years. Though all I know is how to kill, I'll protect you and your child no matter what happens. Just as the Escort King did several decades ago."

Song Ilseom had kept his oath.

He became an escort of the Yongbong Escort Bureau and faithfully followed orders. While he remained at the bureau, he followed the Chief's daughter like a shadow and protected her at her father's request.

As the years passed and the child grew into a beautiful young woman, strange rumors began circulating about the two of them, but he paid them no mind.

Whether the Chief collapsed or the Escort Bureau fell apart, Song Ilseom silently remained in place.

I'm only doing my duty.

Song Ilseom opened his tightly shut eyes and abruptly spoke to Ju Hwaran, who had been watching him.

"I'm leaving in a month."

"…!"

"If you discover the identities of the traitors, I'll lead the way and weed them out. A month will be enough."

Seeing Ju Hwaran's expression, Song Ilseom spoke bluntly.

"Don't make that face. I'm only going to Xianyang to pick up an elixir and bring it back."

"An elixir?"

“That’s right. It should be able to cure the Chief’s illness. The Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng was too potent and might have done more harm than good, but this elixir should definitely work.”

“H-how did you obtain an elixir like that…?”

“Enough. I’m tired of talking, so don’t ask any more questions.”

Song Ilseom waved a hand.

He had managed to secure the elixir after more than two years of searching. It was not a legendary treasure like the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, but nothing else was better suited to restoring the Chief after his qi deviation.

It had cost him every last coin of the enormous fortune he had earned as the Soul-Chasing Guest, but money could always be earned again.

“Do you know something?”

Song Ilseom continued in a quiet voice.

“There’s nothing harder than saving a person’s life. What you took for granted… was the hardest thing in the world for me.”

Song Ilseom had made his living by killing people.

It was only after joining the Yongbong Escort Bureau that he began protecting someone instead.

“Captain Song…”

Ju Hwaran stared at him with glistening eyes, but when she saw his furrowed brow, she hastily corrected herself.

“Ah, Great Hero Song.”

“How long are you going to keep getting that wrong?”

“I’m sorry. I was so surprised that it slipped out…”

“Then why don’t you create a position while you’re at it?”

“Pardon?”

“I don’t want to be Chief Escort. I’m terrible at escort missions, and I’d have to manage people.”

“P-pardon?”

“Guard Hall Master. Yes, that will do.”

While Ju Hwaran was still stammering, Song Ilseom turned and walked away.

Not toward the gate and the darkness beyond it, but toward his own quarters.

“I shouldn’t have packed my bag.”

As she watched Song Ilseom’s back recede with those quiet words trailing behind him, dimples appeared beside Ju Hwaran’s mouth.

Whoosh!

Sails stretched taut and sterns sliced through the current as the swift ships raced forward like the wind. Bare-chested, bronze-skinned men hauled on ropes and pulled at the oars. At least fifty men could be seen on the deck of each ship.

With five swift ships in all, their force numbered nearly three hundred.

“Faster! Faster!”

“You louts! How can you call yourselves members of the Water Dragon Stronghold when you’re that slow?”

The Water Dragon Stronghold was a major river stronghold belonging to the Yangtze River Channel League.

Its members proudly called themselves the heroes of the Yangtze, but ordinary people had a rather less flattering name for them.

“River bandits! They’re river bandits!”

“Why the hell are those bastards here?”

The shipmaster who spotted the five fast ships promptly collapsed into his seat.

These were no ragtag thugs. They were the Water Dragon Stronghold of the Yangtze River Channel League. There was no outrunning their swift ships, and fighting them was out of the question.

This day has gone completely to hell.

No. There was only one way to get through this quietly, at least.

Looking utterly dejected, the shipmaster called over the youngest sailor passing by.

“Hey!”

“Yes, shipmaster.”

“Tell the passengers to pay up.”

“Pardon?”

“Collect the money! They have to pay the toll, don’t they?”

The fact that they belonged to the Yangtze River Channel League was both unfortunate and fortunate. Once they were caught, there was no way to escape, but they did not simply swing their swords without reason.

The Yangtze River Channel League claimed this set them apart from the common river-bandit rabble found everywhere under heaven, but one pack of bastards was much the same as another.

“Phew… I’ve really lost today’s business.”

The shipmaster was heaving sigh after sigh when someone tapped him on the shoulder.

“Excuse me.”

“Gah! You startled me! Who are you?”

“I’m a passenger.”

“I know that.”

The shipmaster studied the young man who had appeared out of nowhere. Judging by the sword at his waist, he seemed to be a martial artist, but…

He looks kind of dopey. That mouth of his sticks out, too. Bet he never shuts up.

Third Rate martial artists were a dime a dozen.

It wasn't as if he had never dealt with one or two of them before. The shipmaster sighed and opened his mouth.

"What do you want? If this is about the money, I've got nothing to say. Go back to your seat. Don't try anything stupid and end up crossing the Sanzu River."[1689]

The young man watched the swift ships drawing rapidly closer.

"Are they river bandits?"

"Can't you tell by looking? They're from the Water Dragon Stronghold of the Yangtze River Channel League. There isn't a soul in Sichuan who doesn't know them."

"The Yangtze River Channel League…"

"Running won't help. You'll never escape those swift ships. Once they spot you, it's over. Completely over!"

"That ship must be pretty fast."

"What kind of question is—"

The shipmaster was about to snap at him when he sucked in a breath and clamped his mouth shut.

A shadow had risen behind the young man, a full head taller than him.

The giant had shaggy hair, and a great mound of hides rose high atop the pack frame on his back.

He stared blankly at the shipmaster, then spoke to the young man.

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Let's take that ship."

The shipmaster wondered if he had heard correctly.

[1689] The Sanzu River is a Buddhist river believed to mark the boundary between life and death.

Chapter 331

Ship-Fire Boy. A child who lights the fires aboard a ship.

The term meant a boatman. It was also the sobriquet of one particular man.

“Stronghold Lord.”

At his subordinate’s call, the man sitting cross-legged in the center of the cabin opened his eyes.

A crystalline gleam flashed in them. His skin was bronze and his body muscular, befitting a hardened river man. His bulging temples marked him as a Peak master who had reached a considerable realm.

“What is it?”

A deep, resonant voice emerged between his dry lips. His subordinate answered with the utmost respect.

“There’s a vessel fifty zhang[1690] away.”

“A vessel? Brothers from our alliance?”

“No.”

Then there was only one possibility.

On the mighty Yangtze, there were only those who robbed and those who were robbed.

“How many?”

“A little over fifty. It doesn’t appear to be a merchant ship, either.”

“I see.”

“What should we do?”

“Deal with it quietly. Don’t cause a commotion.”

With that, the man closed his eyes again.

A warship sent by the imperial court might have warranted his personal attention. This matter was far too trivial.

As always, his subordinates would carry out his orders.

Interrupting my meditation over something so insignificant.

The man let go of his irritation and sank back into contemplation.

It had already been more than ten years since he reached the Peak realm. Now, however, an invisible wall stood in his path.

He had tried consuming stolen elixirs and even smoking opium, which was said to reveal sights one had never experienced before. All of it had been a waste of time.

This is going to be difficult at this rate.

Water Dragon Stronghold was one of the ten largest strongholds in the Yangtze River Channel League.

[1690] Here, fifty zhang is about 152 m (497 ft), using the Korean jang of ten cheok.

Thanks to its location in Sichuan, through which vast quantities of goods passed, it was known as one of the most lucrative strongholds in the alliance.

But the man had only just entered his forties, and his ambitions were greater still.

Alliance Leader.

His goal was to become the master of the Yangtze River Channel League—and, with it, the king of the Yangtze.

Anyone unaware of his circumstances might scoff at such a preposterous ambition, but the man possessed both the ability and the background to make it possible.

The proof was that he had become lord of Water Dragon Stronghold more than ten years ago, when he was barely past thirty.

"Whooo…"

The man drew a long breath. As he drew in and circulated the natural qi permeating the air, his sharpened senses gathered information from his surroundings.

The damp smell of water. The swift ship gradually slowing beneath him. Even the shouts and laughter of his subordinates.

"Hahaha! Running into us means you bastards have the worst luck imaginable. Who owns this ship?"

"I-I do, sir."

"You launched your ship without permission from us heroes. I assume you're prepared for the consequences?"

"I-I've committed a crime worthy of death by failing to recognize the heroes of the Yangtze. This isn't much, but please accept it as a token of my sincerity…"

Wham! Crash!

A blow landed, and someone went sprawling. The man's brow furrowed at the shrill screams that followed.

I told them not to make a commotion.

No martial artist enjoyed having his training interrupted. His men might be rough and ignorant, but he had not expected them to be incapable of following such a simple order.

The man's eyes snapped open. He was about to spring to his feet when—

Boom! Crack! Thud! Th-th-th-thump!

A savage barrage of noise erupted, and then everything fell silent.

It seems to be over.

Somewhat mollified, the man closed his eyes again.

Or he would have, if not for the question that suddenly crossed his mind.

But…why is it so quiet?

Step. Step. Step.

Low, resonant footsteps approached the cabin.

At last, someone stopped directly outside the door and spoke through a yawn.

“What are you doing? Aren’t you coming out?”

“…!”

An unfamiliar voice. He had never heard it before.

Alarm bells rang in the man’s mind.

An enemy!

Everything happened in an instant.

The man shot to his feet and streaked toward the door like a beam of light.

His fist, carrying enough power to smash apart a massive sailing ship, shattered the thick wooden door and hurtled toward the enemy beyond it.

And then—

Kraaaang!

A deafening boom and its aftershock rocked the swift ship.

The man stared wide-eyed at his enemy.

More precisely, at the palm that had stopped his fist.

A seething voice escaped between his clenched teeth.

“Who are you?”

“Me?”

The young man answered with a faint smile.

“The owner of this ship.”

Flames poured from the eyes of the man known as the Ship-Fire Boy, Mu Song.

“How dare a little pup like you… I’ll show you the sky.”

I kicked the leg of the middle-aged man sprawled flat on his back across the deck.

“How long are you going to keep staring at the sky? Get up. Quickly.”

Focus returned to his hazy eyes. The middle-aged man propped up his upper body and stared at me with a dazed expression.

“H-how did you defeat the Ship-Breaking Fist so easily…?”

“Wait. Ship-Breaking Fist?”

Right. Now I remembered.

I had definitely seen that martial art somewhere before, but the memory had been so hazy that I couldn’t place it.

Intrigued, I looked the middle-aged man up and down.

“What’s your relationship with Cheol Soo?”

“Cheol… Soo? Who are you talking about?”

"You know. Cheol Soo. Cheol Soo…"

Gung Gibang quietly cut in.

"The Iron-Water Divine Dragon."

"Right. The Iron-Water Divine Dragon. When I met him at the Star-Array Grand Banquet, he kept going on about the Ship-Breaking Fist too."

If I remembered correctly, it had been during the first preliminary round.

He had spouted some bullshit about how I should consider it an honor to witness the Ship-Breaking Fist, so I had smashed a cliff apart with the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

I heard he forfeited right afterward and went straight home.

It had happened only a month ago here in the Murim, but after everything I had been through, it felt like the distant past.

In any case, the middle-aged man before me had learned the same martial art as the Iron-Water Divine Dragon. He was also a Peak master, a cut above Cheol Soo in skill.

After blinking at me like a goldfish, he stammered in a trembling voice.

"W-were you acquainted with my youngest?"

"Your youngest?"

"The Cheol Soo you mentioned is the youngest of us three martial brothers. He's the third Disciple, and I'm the second."

Huh. I had heard that before too.

People had gone on endlessly about the Iron-Water Divine Dragon's Master.

"Then, could it be…?"

The middle-aged man nodded.

"That's right. My Master is the man known as the Seafaring King."

"Jang Bogo!"[1691]

"…?"

"No, it's nothing. I was just talking to myself."

"But why are you suddenly being so polite…?"

"Of course I should be polite. You're my Senior in the martial world and a hero of the Yangtze River Channel League. Please, feel free to speak casually to me."

To be honest, the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance both looked like criminal organizations full of social misfits to me.

But…

If he's the Seafaring King's Disciple, that changes things.

The Seafaring King would hardly be pleased to hear that I had beaten his Disciple black and blue to steal his swift ship.

[1691] Jang Bogo was a ninth-century Korean maritime commander, making him Taekyung's spontaneous guess at the identity of the "Seafaring King."

At least with the Green Forest Alliance's Heavenly Axe, I had been fully justified, so they couldn't complain. In this case, though, it would be better to smooth things over.

I helped the bewildered middle-aged man to his feet and brushed the dust from his clothes.

"Look how dirty your clothes got. What a disaster. You'll have to get them dry-cleaned."

"W-why are you suddenly acting like this?"

"I told you to speak casually with me. There was an unfortunate incident because of a minor misunderstanding on my part, but if I'd known you belonged to the renowned Yangtze River Channel League, I would have settled everything amicably through conversation. You understand, right?"

"…Really?"

"Of course. Do I look like the sort of ill-bred junior who would lie to his Senior?"

The middle-aged man stared at me for a moment, then cautiously shifted his gaze upward.

I followed his eyes and saw a flag rising high above the fast ship.

The words emblazoned across it were large enough to read from a hundred meters[1692] away.

Yangtze River Channel League.

"…"

"…"

I finally spoke in a grave voice.

"I'm illiterate. I can't read."

"…"

Yeah. I knew he wouldn't buy it.

I clenched my fist and looked at the middle-aged man.

"Let's just settle this amicably."

"…Very well."

Whoooosh.

The swift ship sliced powerfully through the water. Cheongpung, who had been sitting at the bow enjoying the wind, came racing over and began chattering excitedly.

"Benefactor! It's so refreshing!"

"Of course it is. It's still early spring."

[1692] A hundred meters is about 328 ft.

“There are so many fish too!”

“There should be. It’s a river.”

“There are so many people on the ship over there, and they’re getting beaten so much!”

“Of course they’re getting beaten—wait, what?”

What had I just heard?

As I doubted my ears, Cheongpung answered with an innocent smile.

“Every time the captain swings that huge oar, their skin tears and blood sprays everywhere!”

“…”

It seemed Mu Song had lined up his subordinates and was beating them one after another with an oar.

They had mistakenly attacked a passenger ship and suffered a tremendous humiliation, so I supposed it was understandable.

“Pretend you didn’t see anything. You saw nothing.”

“Can I ask him to let me hit one of them just once?”

“No. Please don’t.”

Ignoring the surrounding sailors, who were staring at Cheongpung as if wondering whether he was even human, I turned to Gung Gibang.

“Hey, if you knew, you should’ve told me beforehand.”

“Am I some kind of fortune-teller? How am I supposed to know who’s stationed at every single stronghold?”

Gung Gibang stared at me incredulously, then muttered under his breath.

“The crazy bastard is the one who charged in after seeing the Yangtze River Channel League’s flag. Bit late to complain now.”

“Hey, I can hear you.”

“You were supposed to. You don’t fucking listen even when I tell you something. What the hell do you expect me to do?”

“Damn, you’ve gotten awfully bold. What do you think of this insubordination, Mujin?”

Hyuk Mujin answered.

“Uweeeeeegh!”

“…Your seasickness is pretty bad. Get some rest.”

For someone who was supposedly a Supreme First Rate master, he was still in terrible shape.

Cheongpung watched Hyuk Mujin cling to the railing and dry-heave again and again, then twisted enviously from side to side.

“I want to get seasick too. I’ve never tried it before.”

“…”

Lucky you. So many things you still want to experience.

Maybe it was because I was on a boat, but today I was experiencing the power of the Bermuda Triangle all over again.

Am I going to end up adrift on the Yangtze?

As that thought crossed my mind, the hulking Mu Song landed on the deck using a light, elusive movement technique completely at odds with his massive build.

He tossed the blood-soaked oar to a subordinate and approached me.

“Are you uncomfortable anywhere?”

“Ah, yes. I’m comfortable, Senior.”

Mu Song glanced at Hyuk Mujin, who was still dry-heaving.

“That fellow doesn’t look very comfortable.”

“That’s all right. I’m comfortable.”

“…”

“Is there a problem?”

“No, no. In any case, you’re headed to Chengdu?”

“Yes. How long will it take?”

“We’re currently at Guang’an, which could be considered the entrance to Sichuan. At this speed, three days. If we catch a favorable wind, two days will be more than enough.”

That was about the same speed as traveling with a movement technique, perhaps even a little faster.

An ordinary vessel would have taken much longer, but this was one of the swift ships for which the Yangtze River Channel League was renowned.

I sincerely clasped my hands in a respectful salute.

“Thank you.”

“Nonsense. It’s no great trouble.”

Mu Song was being so cooperative because he had learned who our group was.

I was the Disciple of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. Gung Gibang was the Successor Beggar of the Beggars’ Sect. Cheongpung had inherited the true transmission of the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak.

And finally, the great Jin Family of Taiyuan’s…

Ah, let’s leave that last one out.

“In any case, Chengdu is close, so rest comfortably while you wait. This Mu Song has the rivers flowing through Sichuan firmly under his control.”

“Wow. That’s impressive, Senior.”

“Without my orders, no one dares do anything foolish on the Yangtze. Hahahaha!”

At that exact moment, faint cries drifted over from far away.

“Aaaah!”

“Kill them all and take everything!”
I muttered as the distant screams reached us.
“They seem pretty good at doing foolish things…”
Mu Song’s face flushed bright red.
“How dare anyone run wild on the Yangtze!”

Chapter 332

“Who dares run wild on the Yangtze?”

Not that I expected an answer from all the way over there.

Letting Mu Song’s shout go in one ear and out the other, I circulated my internal energy and sharpened my eyesight.

The distance was easily over two hundred zhang.[1693] But my vision had improved enough that you could call me a human eagle, allowing me to take in the entire scene at a glance.

That’s…

River bandits.

Two ships far larger than the swift ship we were riding had surrounded one tiny boat. Black specks that looked like arrows and harpoons flew toward it without pause.

Then I spotted the flags fluttering from the bandits’ ships, and my gaze naturally shifted toward Mu Song.

“I don’t know what kind of scum they are, but they picked the wrong target. You there! Immediately deal with those rootless bastards… What’s wrong?”

“Uh, Senior. I’m not quite sure how to put this.”

“What?”

“That unaffiliated rabble looks like they belong to the Yangtze River Channel League.”

“…?”

“…?”

After a brief silence, Mu Song roared, “That’s impossible!”

“No, it’s entirely possible. Their flag says ‘Yangtze River Channel League’ in very bold lettering.”

“Didn’t you say you were illiterate a moment ago?”

Was he a river bandit or a razor? He was surprisingly sharp.

Instead of panicking, I hardened my expression.

“I’m a fast learner. Besides, is that really important right now? Every moment counts! We need to punish those lawless thugs disrupting order on the Yangtze!”

Mu Song looked as if he wanted to punish me first, but he wholeheartedly agreed with my point.

“Exactly. In this day and age, how dare they commit murder on the Yangtze… I’ll kill every last one of them with a single palm strike!”

[1693] A zhang is ten Korean ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

It was a little depressing to hear that from a river-bandit chief, but according to something Gung Gibang had casually told me, Mu Song belonged to the moderate faction within the Yangtze River Channel League.

His philosophy was that taking people's money was enough. Why take their lives too?

"…"

He was still taking their money.

Come to think of it, they were all much the same. Still, in a Murim where people drew their swords at the slightest provocation, he really was conscientious for a top-tier river bandit—especially one who was a Disciple of the Alliance Leader of the Yangtze River Channel League.

"Raise the red flag!"

At Mu Song's booming command, the five swift ships raised the red flags that signaled battle and surged forward.

Whoooooosh!

The sails swelled taut in a timely gust of wind. Built for maximum speed, the swift ships sliced through the current and devoured the distance between us.

The two-hundred-zhang[1694] gap shrank by half in an instant. Among the river bandits preparing for close-quarters battle, urgent shouts rang out.

"S-swift ships!"

"Mu Song of Water Dragon Stronghold is here! Everyone, retreat!"

But Mu Song was not about to let them escape.

Barely fifty zhang[1695] now separated us from the enemy. A fierce light flashed in his eyes as he glared at the bandits scrambling back to their ships.

"Let's at least see what you bastards look like!"

Grinding his teeth, Mu Song snatched up a massive harpoon, kicked off the stern, and leaped into the air.

Boom!

The sturdy wooden deck splintered, and the Yangtze swallowed Mu Song's body as it arced through the air.

Isn't that dangerous?

Mistaking the Yangtze for some valley stream in Gangwon Province would be a serious mistake.

Although this was a branch of the Yangtze that split away from the main channel, it was as wide and deep as the sea, and the current was viciously rough.

Even Hyuk Mujin, who had been dry-heaving, asked with a pale face, "Shouldn't we rescue him—uweeegh!"

[1694] A zhang is ten Korean ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1695] A zhang is ten Korean ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“Gibang, pat that bastard on the back.”

“I’m not his nanny…”

Of course he wasn’t. Who would hire a beggar as a nanny?

Despite his grumbling, Gung Gibang pounded Hyuk Mujin on the back.

“There’s a limit to ignorance. Do you think a river bandit chief would jump into the Yangtze without learning water-based martial arts? Especially a Disciple of the Seafaring King, who no one can match in the water?”

“Oh, right.”

“I don’t know who those bastards are, but they’ve tangled with the wrong man. There’ll be a string of funerals today. Tsk, tsk.”

Gung Gibang’s prediction was accurate.

A few seconds later, Mu Song surfaced more than ten zhang[1696] ahead of the swift ship.

Spla-aaash!

Every time his massive body traced a supple curve like a wave, he shot forward like a water-skier. My jaw dropped.

“Unbelievable!”

He was even faster than the swift ship.

The sight of Mu Song charging toward the enemy vessel like a fish-man made my own blood boil.

“Since it’s come to this, I’m going too!”

Gung Gibang shrieked, “Going where?”

“Uweeegh!”

“Benefactor, me too!”

“Get lost, all of you! The Grand Line[1697] is calling me! The Yangtze is calling me!”

Breaking free of the Bermuda Triangle, I raced across the deck and launched myself from the bow with all my strength.

Boom! Craaack!

The bow shattered under the force. Weightlessness swept over me as the wind slammed into my face.

Whooooooosh!

“Freedom! Freedom!”

I became a bird.

Then I lost momentum and began to fall.

“Senior!”

“Gasp!”

[1696] A zhang is ten Korean ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1697] The Grand Line is the central ocean route in the manga *One Piece*.

Tap!

I landed lightly on the back of a passing fish-man.

Angle, speed, distance, landing point. This result was only possible because I had calculated everything perfectly.

“Whew. Per-fect.”

“What part of that was perfect!”

Mu Song roared at his unexpected passenger, but what could he do? I was already aboard.

I glared at the river bandits frantically turning their ships around.

“Let’s go!”

“Damn it! Since it’s come to this, we’ll charge straight into the ship!”

“That’s my Senior!”

“We’ll settle this when this is over!”

Spla-aaash!

Gritting his teeth, Mu Song increased his speed even further.

The river bandits had only just regained their footing and were frantically trying to escape, but it was already too late.

We had become a single harpoon hurtling toward the side of their ship.

“Go, Senior! Fish-Man Jujutsu:[1698] Current—One-Arm Shoulder Throw!”

“Yaaaargh!”

Mu Song and I screamed at the top of our lungs and thrust out our arms at the same time.

He held a harpoon and I held a spear, but our weapons had one thing in common.

Powerful qi gathered at the tips of both weapons.

Whooooooosh!

Two blasts of Spear Energy tore through the wind and burrowed into the ship’s damp, sturdy hull.

The next instant—

Kwaaang! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A thunderous roar erupted with an enormous shock wave.

“Mujin.”

At my solemn voice, Hyuk Mujin finally stopped retching and answered with a pale face.

“Yes?”

“I think I was born to be a river bandit.”

[1698] Fish-Man Jujutsu is a water-based martial art used by fish-men in *One Piece*.

“What kind of nonsense is that?”

“Do you want to hear yourself wail?”

“I misspoke because I’m not feeling well. Now that I think about it, the role suits you perfectly.”

“Right?”

“Yes. I can still vividly see you recklessly—no, courageously—smashing straight through that ship.”

“What a rush.”

I nodded smugly and gazed at the slowly sinking ship.

On one side, Mu Song’s men had divided themselves among the small ferryboats carried aboard the swift ships and were pulling floundering river bandits from the water.

On the other ship, the river bandits hung their heads as they were transferred to the swift ships one after another, bound together with ropes.

One ship sunk. The other captured.

An excellent result for my first naval battle.

Originally, I had planned to sink both ships. But the river bandits lost their will to fight as soon as they saw the ship carrying their comrades sink, and they surrendered.

Of course, surrender did not lead to a particularly happy ending.

“How dare scum like you tarnish the name of the Yangtze River Channel League?”

Moderate or not, Mu Song was still a martial artist who had no qualms about killing and a river bandit who had spent his life on the unforgiving Yangtze.

Once he snapped, there was no stopping him.

“Throw them to the fish.”

The tightly bound river bandits opened their eyes wide.

“T-this can’t be happening!”

“Stronghold Lord! Please, anything but that!”

Mu Song answered them with an icy stare.

“Stronghold Lord? You belong to a different stronghold. Why would I be your Stronghold Lord? And don’t worry. Your chief will be joining you soon, so you won’t be lonely.”

“We were wrong! Please, just this once…!”

“If you were willing to invade Water Dragon Stronghold’s territory and do something like this, you should have been prepared for the consequences. Do you know why I had my men pull you out of the water? So I could punish you with my own hands.”

Mu Song jerked his chin, and his subordinates stepped forward and dragged the river bandits away.

The river bandits screamed as death closed in, but their limbs were already bound. One splash after another rang out as they sank beneath the surface.

Cheongpung bit his lip, his face pale, as more than fifty river bandits were drowned alive before his eyes.

No wonder.

Someone who was afraid even of blood could hardly endure a sight like this.

Despite myself, I grew concerned and spoke to him quietly.

“Close your eyes. I’ll tell you when it’s over.”

“No, Benefactor. I’m fine.”

“They may deserve to die, but you’re still watching people die. It might be hard to look at.”

“No.”

“Hm?”

Cheongpung’s eyes twitched.

“I’m just… trying to get used to it.”

Get used to it? I had never expected to hear something like that from Cheongpung.

Cheongpung was kind by nature, and unlike other young men his age, he had not been tainted by the ways of the world.

Perhaps that was why he feared blood and had always avoided killing. But now, I sensed a steely resolve within him.

Was it the battle with the Blood Lord at Mount Song? Did it begin then?

His first encounter with the fear and terror of death must have awakened something inside him.

Part of me was proud of him. Another part felt bitter.

It can’t be helped. This is the Murim.

That was right. This was the Murim—and the storm clouds of war were gathering.

He could not remain an innocent mountain youth forever in a place like this.

If this helped him grow… maybe it was for the best.

Cheongpung fought to keep his eyes from closing. At last, he let out a sigh of relief.

The river bandits had finally been dealt with.

But it was not over yet.

“Hwang Tae-gu. Now it’s your turn.”

Mu Song’s low voice rang across the deck.

Unlike the other river bandits, a man in his fifties had been forced to his knees before Mu Song, tightly bound in chains.

Hwang Tae-gu was the mastermind behind this attack.

Gung Gibang muttered as he watched him.

“I was wondering why Mu Song was here. So that’s what happened.”

“What do you mean?”

“Even the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families have their factions. Imagine how bad it must be in a band of river bandits like the Yangtze River Channel League.”

“So this Hwang Tae-gu lost a factional struggle?”

“He was famous for being greedy and violent. Just a few years ago, he lorded over the Yangtze in Sichuan… There’s no doubt Mu Song pushed him out.”

So the loser of an internal power struggle had gone rogue and finally gotten himself caught?

As I considered that, Hwang Tae-gu opened his mouth.

“I have nothing to say to some ignorant young punk. Kill me.”

“You’ll get your wish whether you say anything or not. But why did you do this?”

“Heh heh. What a stupid question. I’m a river bandit. What’s wrong with a river bandit killing and taking what he wants?”

“There’s no reasoning with you. I should have killed you long ago.”

Mu Song’s face hardened, and he raised his harpoon.

“Would Great Hero Mu Song, the Ship-Fire Boy, please wait a moment?”

A voice suddenly rang out, piercing the ears of everyone present.

Chapter 333

“Great Hero Mu Song, the Ship-Fire Boy, could you wait a moment?”

I wanted to give the owner of that voice a standing ovation.

Think about it. Who could say something like that in a situation like this?

Especially when the person they were addressing was a river-bandit chief who had thrown around fifty river bandits to the fish in five minutes.

But who was it?

Judging by the way he called Mu Song a Great Hero, he obviously isn’t in this line of work.

Mu Song’s subordinates called him Stronghold Lord or Chief, so that ruled them out. None of my companions, myself included, had said a word, so that ruled us out too.

That left…

The passengers who were attacked by the river bandits.

Everyone else had clearly reached the same conclusion.

My companions and I—even the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold. Every head turned in the same direction, toward the twenty passengers who had moved onto the swift ship when Hwang Tae-gu’s attack left their boat listing.

“Who is it? Step forward.”

At Mu Song’s fierce glare, his harpoon hanging low in one hand, his subordinates hurriedly cleared a path. A lone figure stood at the end of it.

“It was me.”

I had guessed as much from the voice, but he was quite young. No, he looked almost boyish.

Twenty at most, if I’m being generous?

Boy suited him better than young man. Flustered by everyone’s attention, he hesitated, then awkwardly clasped his hands together.

“I-I’m Mungyeong.”

“Mungyeong?”

Mu Song frowned.

“Never heard the name. And from the look of you, you aren’t a martial artist.”

Mu Song had a good eye.

The boy, Mungyeong, had the aura of an ordinary commoner. Nothing more, nothing less.

Mungyeong swallowed nervously under our scrutiny and answered,

“T-That’s right. I’m merely a medical apprentice still in training. I have no connection to the Murim.”

"A medical apprentice? Then how do you know me?"

"How could I not know of the righteous boatman on the Yangtze in Sichuan who keeps such a strict rein on bloodshed?"

Now that was some serious flattery.

Mu Song's mouth twitched as he went from a river-bandit chief who controlled Sichuan's waterways and shook down travelers to a righteous boatman in the blink of an eye.

"Hmm. Is that so?"

"Wealth comes and goes, but a man has only one life. Those who know how many lives were lost on the Yangtze until just a few years ago call you the Great Hero of Benevolence and Righteousness."

"Ahem. There's no need to go that far. Being called the Hero of the Yangtze is enough for me."

What a load of horseshit…

Mu Song was reasonably sensible, but he was still a river bandit. Keeping his thuggery within reasonable bounds didn't make him a model citizen.

But the young medical apprentice seemed to see things differently.

"My parents died tragically on the Yangtze more than ten years ago. If Great Hero Mu Song hadn't saved me, I would have met the same fate."

"Oh, dear. That's unfortunate. But if it was more than ten years ago…"

"That's right."

Mungyeong continued in a trembling voice.

"The man kneeling before you is my parents' killer."

"Good heavens."

The river bandits and passengers who had been listening intently let out low groans. Mu Song nodded as if he understood and spoke.

"Now I understand why you asked me to stop. Though it goes against the League regulations, I understand how you feel. I'll give you the chance."

"You mean you'll let me decide whether he lives or dies?"

"Of course."

But Mungyeong's answer defied everyone's expectations—including mine.

"Then… please let him live."

"…!"

"…!"

Mu Song had been about to hand Mungyeong the harpoon he was holding. Even Hwang Tae-gu, who had already closed his eyes as though resigned to everything, snapped them open and stared at Mungyeong.

"W-What did you say?"

When Mu Song asked again in confusion, Mungyeong bowed at the waist.

“I desperately wish to avenge my parents, but I am a medical apprentice. How can one who deals in life bring about death? I beg you to cripple his martial arts and punish him according to strict law, so that he can never commit evil again.”

“If we do as you ask, he’ll be taken to League headquarters. He deserves to die, but with all the connections he’s made over the years, he may manage to save his life. Wouldn’t it be better to take your revenge with your own hands, right here?”

“I have no connection to the Murim, but I have often heard that, for a martial artist, losing one’s martial arts is the same as death. I may not have killed him, but would that not be as good as killing him? And…”

Mungyeong gazed at Hwang Tae-gu with clear eyes.

“This is not about personal revenge, but the greater good. If the Yangtze River Channel League punishes him itself, would that not serve as a warning to others who commit such slaughter?”

Not a trace of trembling remained in the boy’s resolute voice. His words held a conviction that made those listening nod along.

Exclamations rose from the crowd.

“Well, I’ll be. That young fellow is something else.”

“If it were me, I’d have shoved that harpoon straight into his chest.”

“He’s remarkable in more ways than one. He’ll make a fine physician.”

Mu Song also seemed deeply impressed by Mungyeong’s well-reasoned argument. He nodded admiringly and stepped in front of Hwang Tae-gu.

“If your ears work, you heard him. What do you think?”

“I-I’ll survive, and I’ll tear every one of you apart!”

The killing intent flashing in Hwang Tae-gu’s eyes did not last long.

Thud!

“Guh!”

Mu Song’s toe drove into the spot beneath Hwang Tae-gu’s navel—the place known as the dantian.

Mu Song looked down coldly at Hwang Tae-gu, who toppled backward, vomiting blood.

“Go ahead and survive, then. See if you can carry out your threat. With your dantian shattered, though, you’ll hardly be alive even if you live.”

With a sharp crack of displaced air, Mu Song’s foot lashed out and struck Hwang Tae-gu’s dantian again.

Whoooooom! Crack!

“Guh! N-No!”

By the time Hwang Tae-gu’s scream echoed hollowly across the deck, everything was already over.

Ssshhh.

I can feel it.

Qi streamed from his twitching seven apertures[1699] and scattered into the air.

When a cup holding water breaks, the water spills out. The moment his qi-sea acupoint was destroyed, the internal energy stored in his dantian disappeared.

"You bastards! I swear I'll—!"

The Peak master who had once commanded countless ships and ruled the Yangtze in Sichuan no longer existed.

Hwang Tae-gu was now nothing more than a powerless man in his fifties. He kept shouting until Mu Song silenced him with a Pressure-Point Strike, leaving his entire body rigid.

"What a noisy bastard. Throw him somewhere out of the way. We'll escort him to League headquarters later."

"Yes."

A bald, copper-skinned river bandit who looked like Diglett[1700] hoisted Hwang Tae-gu onto his back and disappeared. For the moment, the matter was settled.

Mu Song scratched the back of his head and looked around at the crowd.

"Well, this is awkward. I've shown you all an ugly sight. I offer my sincere apologies to everyone who suffered through this incident."

So a good bandit defeated a bad bandit?

In any case, the commoners whose lives had been saved by Water Dragon Stronghold bowed repeatedly.

"Oh, no, not at all. Without the Heroes of the Yangtze, we would have been done for."

"We don't know how we could ever repay this debt…"

"Perhaps the Primordial Heavenly Venerable[1701] was watching over us. Not a single person died, so you needn't worry."

Huh? Not one person died?

At those words, I looked over the passengers.

It's true.

There were injured people here and there, but no corpses.

Mu Song and I had arrived before the battle turned into a full-scale melee, but the river bandits had definitely fired arrows and harpoons at them from a distance.

How had a mere twenty commoners all survived?

It didn't take long for me to get my answer.

"If that young medical apprentice hadn't been here, we might all have died."

[1699] The seven apertures are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

[1700] Diglett is a Pokémon depicted as a small brown head emerging from the ground.

[1701] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is a deity in Daoism.

“Indeed. How could anyone remain so calm in a situation like that? He’s truly remarkable.”

The conversation I overheard went like this.

When the passengers spotted the approaching river bandits and panicked, Mungyeong stepped forward. He had them tear up the deck and use the planks as shields, then ordered them to break the mast.

Tearing up the deck is one thing, but breaking the mast?

An ordinary person would have thought first of rowing for their life and escaping. Mungyeong had done the opposite.

He broke the sails and left the boat’s fate to the violent current of the Yangtze, which heaved and rolled like a whirlpool.

And it worked.

I knew roughly how naval battles worked.

After firing from a distance, the usual tactic was to close in and ram the other ship, or hook it with ropes and board it for close combat.

But if the target had completely lost the ability to steer and was spinning and pitching wildly, finding an opening wouldn’t be easy. That was how Mungyeong had bought them time.

Well, look at this guy.

Then there was his decision regarding Hwang Tae-gu. This was no ordinary clever boy.

Perhaps he felt my gaze. Mungyeong, who had been smiling awkwardly at all the praise directed his way, flinched.

“Y-Young Hero. Did you need something from me?”

“What would I need? Judging by your age, you could be my little brother. I was just looking at you because you did something impressive.”

“Th-That’s too much praise.”

“From what I heard, that was pretty bold. How did you come up with it?”

“Although I’m training to become a medical apprentice now, before my parents passed away, I used to read all kinds of miscellaneous books.”

“Miscellaneous books?”

“Yes. Believe it or not, my family comes from a humble military household. My grandfather was also a military officer who received a stipend from the court.”

He was trying to hide both his faint wariness of a stranger and a quiet sense of pride.

Seen this way, he wasn’t much different from any other boy his age.

But something about him didn’t sit right.

I studied Mungyeong carefully and muttered inwardly.

Skill, activate Qi Sense.

Ding.

Along with the familiar chime, information about him rose into the air.

“I guessed wrong.”

“Pardon?”

“Nothing. Stay healthy, eat well, and grow up strong.”

“Y-Yes…”

Clicking my tongue inwardly, I turned away from the bewildered Mungyeong.

Mu Song, who had been watching, spoke to me quietly.

“What was that about?”

“Nothing important. I just took a personal interest in him.”

“Junior, do you happen to have a taste for men?”

You fucking bastard…

When he saw my expression, Mu Song cleared his throat and changed the subject.

“Ahem. In any case, we should continue on our way. The current is rough, but the wind is favorable, so we should reach Xi’an soon.”

“What about the others? Their original boat was listing too.”

“The others? Ah, my men will take them somewhere safe.”

Mu Song chuckled and added,

“Of course, we’ll accept a small token of their appreciation.”

“…”

Saving their lives, then shaking them down for money. Was that clever or stupid?

I was briefly struck speechless by this novel form of creative economics when—

“W-Wait a moment.”

“Hm?”

It was Mungyeong. Glancing around nervously, he fidgeted with his fingers before speaking.

“Um, did you say you were going to Xi’an?”

“That’s right. Why?”

Mungyeong gasped, then spilled out his words in a rush.

“The thing is, I happen to be on my way to Xi’an too. If you would give me a ride just this once, I’ll repay this kindness even beyond the grave, remember it to my very bones, and even if this body dies and dies, dies a thousand times over and turns to white bones, I will never forget—”

What is this?

I let out a long sigh at the Jeong Mong-ju villain.[1702]

“Fine. Get on.”

“Thank you!”

As Mungyeong hurried off to gather his luggage, Mu Song muttered under his breath,

“Wait, this is my ship…”

Yeah. No.

[1702] Jeong Mong-ju was a Goryeo scholar-official remembered for a famous vow of loyalty in which he declared that even if he died a hundred deaths and his bones turned to dust, his loyalty would remain unchanged.

Chapter 334

Time flowed like a river.

It was a common, well-worn metaphor, but that was exactly how my three days aboard the swift ship passed.

Thanks to this ship, we cut down our travel time by quite a bit.

True to the name Yangtze River Channel League, Mu Song and the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold were all outstanding sailors. They knew the lower reaches of the Yangtze, which ran throughout Sichuan, as well as the palms of their hands.

“We’ll be there soon, Old Master.”

I gazed at Jeok Cheongang’s wrinkled face as I murmured.

Only a few weeks had passed, but his already small, thin body was gradually weakening.

It was something I realized every time I used True Qi Guidance to bolster his qi, as I had today.

Recovery is impossible. For now, the best I can do is slow the decline.

He had only lasted this long because he was a Supreme Peak master with profound internal energy.

And… our sole hope lay with one person whose medical skills had reached a godly realm.

The Divine Physician.

A mysterious figure whose face, name, age, and even gender were unknown.

The Divine Physician first became known more than forty years ago, though, so I figured they had to be over sixty.

I’ll find the Divine Physician no matter what… and wake you up.

So please, hold on a little longer.

Just as I added those words too softly for anyone else to hear, light footsteps approached. A murmured conversation drifted through the gap in the cabin door.

“Stop, stop, stop. Move, and I’ll cut you.”

“Gasp! Please don’t! You know me.”

“I do. But not even a rat gets past me. That includes some brat who came rolling in from who knows where. You could be an assassin, for all I know.”

“An assassin? I’m a medical apprentice! How could you say something so outrageous?”

“Then what brings you here?”

“G-Great Hero Mu Song asked me to deliver a message.”

“Impossible. Unless you can get past Hyuk Mujin, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, no one can—!”

Bang! Thud!

Mungyeong's jaw dropped as the Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan struck his head on the corner of the door and collapsed.

"He's dead."

"He's not dead."

"B-But a blow like that must have caused serious damage to his head…"

"Enough. What did Senior Mu Song tell you?"

The boy stared back and forth between Hyuk Mujin and me in terror before answering.

"H-He said we're almost there, so you should get ready."

"Oh, really? All right. Gather your things too."

"I'm already packed."

Mungyeong had little luggage.

He pulled his acupuncture and moxibustion supplies from the small bundle clutched to his chest, examined Hyuk Mujin, then sighed in relief.

"Fortunately, his head didn't split open."

"That's because it's made of rock."

"Martial artists really are something else…"

"Oh? Getting cheeky, are we?"

"Gasp! I misspoke!"

I pretended I was about to rap him on the head, and Mungyeong flinched.

A quiet laugh escaped me.

"I'm kidding, you idiot."

"You startled me."

Traveling aboard a swift ship that sailed day and night was surprisingly grueling.

Whenever I finished circulating my internal energy and contemplating martial arts, I wandered the deck for some fresh air. Every time I did, I saw Mungyeong.

He was always checking on everyone else's condition.

He was a good kid. Apparently, he was also quite skilled. Even the river bandits who had been skeptical of him at first often approached him shyly for treatment.

And after talking with him a few times, he seems pretty cheerful too.

Contrary to the mature first impression he had given me, Mungyeong had a lively, boyish side.

Once someone told him who we were, he seemed to take an interest in the Murim and started asking all sorts of questions.

"Young Master Jin, you're the Disciple of Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King? Wow!"

“I’ve heard all about Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint. Young Master Cheong must be incredible too.”

“Wow! The Beggars’ Sect! The Successor Beggar!”

“You’re the Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad? Ah, yes…”

In any case, Mungyeong had naturally blended into our group over those three short days.

Once we reach Chengdu, this will probably be the last time we sit across from each other and talk.

Once we reached Chengdu, our paths would naturally diverge.

I grabbed Mungyeong by the shoulder as he rose onto his toes and peeked over mine.

“Ow! That hurts!”

“What are you so curious about that you’re craning your neck like that?”

“Nothing. I just thought I saw someone’s foot through the gap in the door.”

The boy had sharp eyes. I had hurriedly covered Jeok Cheongang with leather, but Mungyeong had somehow spotted the exposed part.

Still, I answered casually without betraying any panic.

“You imagined it.”

“I don’t think I did…”

“Mungyeong.”

“Yes?”

“Do you really want to see what’s inside?”

He swallowed hard at my ominous tone and began backing away.

“W-Why are you acting like this?”

“I asked you a question. Do you want to see it?”

“No. No, I don’t!”

“Why not? Come inside and take a look. It’ll be fun.”

“Eek!”

Thump! Bang!

Mungyeong stepped on Hyuk Mujin as he backed away, fell over, then scrambled to his feet and fled.

Hyuk Mujin, whose back had been stepped on in the confusion, opened his eyes.

“H-Huh? I could’ve sworn I was just talking to Mungyeong.”

He looked around in bewilderment, then his face stiffened with shock.

“I didn’t even see him strike! He must be an assassin who has reached the Peak realm!”

Smack!

“Argh! Why did you hit me?”

“Stop talking nonsense and gather your things. We’re almost there.”

After giving Hyuk Mujin a satisfying whack on the back of the head, I returned to the cabin, moved Jeok Cheongang onto the pack frame, and stepped out onto the deck.

A giant standing at the stern of the slowing swift ship turned and greeted me.

“Oh, Junior.”

“Yeah, Senior.”

“…Is it just me, or have your answers gotten shorter?”

“It’s entirely your imagination. My voice is naturally a little quiet.”

Mu Song, the giant, stared at me with a dubious expression before calling over one of his subordinates and giving an order.

“Lower the blue flag and raise the white one.”

“Yes, Stronghold Lord.”

It might have sounded like some sort of blue-flag, white-flag game, but this was Water Dragon Stronghold’s signaling system. Apparently, it meant they had no intention of causing trouble.

“This may be an impertinent question, but are river bandits really allowed this close to such a busy area?”

“It is an impertinent question, but I’ll answer it anyway. Yes.”

“How?”

“Can you see it?”

Mu Song pointed toward the slowly approaching pier.

Tall wooden buildings stood packed closely together. Commoners passing by merely glanced at the swift ship before continuing on their way, while a few watched with curiosity.

We might have been far from the city center, but Chengdu was the capital and heart of Sichuan Province. Yet that was the extent of their reaction.

“Well? They all look used to us, don’t they?”

“They do. It’s strange how little attention they’re paying us.”

“It wasn’t always like this. Hwang Tae-gu, that son of a bitch, caused all kinds of trouble before I came along.”

Mu Song ground his teeth before continuing.

“I went through hell trying to change people’s opinion of us. Thanks to that, the authorities turn a blind eye to us now—to a point.”

“The authorities? You mean officials of the Great Nation?”

“That’s right. Dealing with us must have been a nuisance for them too. Formally requesting a fleet from the imperial court would have been burdensome, but staying on high alert every time they encountered us would have worn everyone down. So we reached a compromise.”

"What kind of compromise?"

"I'm different from Hwang Tae-gu. Only a complete idiot kills powerless commoners every time he gets the chance. It's like killing our own customers with our own hands."

"…"

"Of course, I refrain from killing because I dislike bloodshed. Not because of money."

That wasn't very convincing.

No matter how I looked at it, the only reason Mu Song didn't kill people seemed to be money.

What a money-mad river bandit.

I couldn't deny that Mu Song had a talent for shaking people down.

In any case, unlike Hwang Tae-gu, who robbed and killed indiscriminately, the moderate Mu Song had tried negotiating with the authorities and demonstrated considerable skill in doing so.

"Our range of activity has widened a little, while the authorities have received fewer petitions over people being killed by river bandits. Isn't that a benefit to both sides?"

"Even so, they let you come this far?"

"Not officially, of course. Ah, here they come now."

At the end of his gaze was a massive warship equipped with cannons.

Once the ships drew close enough that even people without martial arts could recognize one another, a middle-aged man in full armor suddenly stuck his head out from the stern.

"Who goes there?"

"General, it's me! I've come to put a few people ashore."

"People? Who?"

"My juniors. I'll personally vouch for them."

A river-bandit chief vouching for us. Yeah, that would go over well.

The official called back heartily.

"By all means!"

Fuck, it actually worked.

Mu Song suddenly pulled something from his robe and hurled it.

"Catch!"

The official snatched the bundle out of the air after it sailed toward him in a long arc, then grinned.

"You don't have to do this every time. Thank you. I'll buy you a proper drink next time."

"Sure, let's do that. How is the City Lord?"

“He had a son nine days ago.”

“Oh, what wonderful news. I’ll be sure to attend the doljabi.[1703]”

“Of course. The City Lord will be delighted.”

“Take care, then.”

“I wish you martial fortune, Stronghold Lord!”

For fuck’s sake. The country’s in fine shape.

After their cordial exchange, the warship turned back the way it had come, and the swift ship glided leisurely toward the pier.

“No need to drop anchor, right?”

“Huh? Oh, right.”

“Are you shocked? That’s how the world works. Still, you finally look like a young prodigy your age.”

Fair enough. Worse things happened in the real world, so what was the big deal?

I gave Mu Song, who was laughing heartily, a respectful clasped-fist salute.

“Thank you for your help, Senior. We had a comfortable journey thanks to you.”

“This was nothing. Hardly worth calling help. Just say the word. I am Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song!”

“Ah, truly the greatest Senior! You’ve turned the Yangtze upside down!”

“Ha ha ha!”

I grinned along with Mu Song as he roared with laughter.

“Then I’ll ask for your help again on our way back.”

“…”

“Senior?”

Mu Song stared at me, his eyes trembling.

“I’ll… send my subordinates.”

“Thank you!”

Yangtze taxi. What a steal.

Was it just my imagination, or was the swift ship moving much faster than usual?

I watched it cut frantically through the water as though fleeing a sea monster, then turned around.

The Bermuda Triangle and a beaming young medical apprentice stood there.

“Thanks to you, we arrived quickly. Thank you.”

“The men who rowed and steered did all the work, so why are you thanking me? I don’t know where you’re going or what for, but stay healthy.”

[1703] A doljabi is a Korean first-birthday ceremony in which a child chooses from symbolic objects believed to represent their future.

We had only spent a few days together, but I thought we had formed a pretty good bond.

He was usually innocent and carefree, yet surprisingly thoughtful. It was admirable how well he had endured the pain of losing his parents at such a young age.

I sincerely hoped he would become a fine physician.

“I don’t have a parting gift, but use this for travel expenses.”

I took out a few silver nyang[1704] and pressed them into his hand. Mungyeong stared at me in surprise.

“Y-Young Master, this is…”

“It’s fine. Think of it as allowance from your hyung.[1705]”

“But it’s too much.”

“Then pay me back later. Once you become a physician who can put Hua Tuo[1706]—or rather, the Divine Physician—to shame, come find me at the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“The Divine Physician…?”

“That’s right. If you’re going to do it, you might as well become the best.”

Mungyeong blinked, looking back and forth between me and the silver nyang[1707] in his hand. A faint smile touched his lips.

“Yes. I will.”

“Good. I’m leaving now. Take care.”

After the Bermuda Triangle and I exchanged farewells with Mungyeong, we turned to leave.

Hyuk Mujin, who had suffered through prolonged seasickness, quietly came up beside me and spoke.

“Captain, I’m exhausted. Can’t we rest for half a day before leaving?”

“No. It’s only another half day, so rest when we get there.”

“That’s only half a day if we use a movement technique. And I heard the people of the Sichuan Tang Clan are terrifying… We’ll have to be careful even when we breathe.”

“Then don’t rest. Die.”

“Is that any way to speak to your right-hand man?”

“What? I can’t hear you. My left pinky is mumbling something.”

Just as Hyuk Mujin’s lips jutted out a mile—

“Um, did you say you were going all the way to the Sichuan Tang Clan?”

[1704] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; here it refers to silver money, not modern Korean won.
[1705] Hyung is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.
[1706] Hua Tuo was a Chinese physician of the late Eastern Han period, renowned for his medical skill.
[1707] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; here it refers to silver money, not modern Korean won.

"…"

"…"

We slowly turned our heads.

Mungyeong stood there, his eyes sparkling like morning stars.

"The thing is, I happen to be on my way to the Sichuan Tang Clan too. If you would allow me to accompany you, I would never forget this kindness even if this body died and died, then died ten thousand deaths more, until whether my soul existed or not—"

"Hey."

"Yes?"

"I get it. Shut up and follow us."

Fuck. Now it's the Bermuda Quadrilateral.

Chapter 335

Like Sichuan Province in the real world, Sichuan in this world boasted a vast territory.

Shanxi, Henan, and Shaanxi. You had to combine all three provinces for their total area to rival Sichuan's. That was how enormous it was.

The continent really is something.

With land this vast, it wasn't all that strange for three tigers to coexist in a single province.

The Emei Sect and Qingcheng Sect, both counted among the Nine Sects and One Gang. And…

Finally, the Sichuan Tang Clan. Or the Tang Family.

One of the three tigers crouching in Sichuan, it was also the closest to Chengdu, making it the perfect first destination.

If we can get the cooperation of all three factions and bring the Beggars' Sect into the picture, things should go much more smoothly.

As I was thinking this, Gung Gibang, who had been following a step behind me, pointed ahead.

"We're almost there. The Sichuan Tang Clan."

He was right. A wide basin stretched out before us, with a towering stone wall rising from it.

We were still too far away to judge its exact height, but it looked well over ten meters[1708] tall.

"What the hell? Why did they build a fortress?"

"History taught them a lesson."

"History?"

"They suffered terribly during the Great Faction War. When the Demonic Cult occupied Sichuan, many members of the Tang Family were killed, and even Tang Family Hill, the clan's main base, was burned to the ground."

"Their home base got completely wrecked."

"It wasn't that one-sided. As they retreated, they released all kinds of deadly poisons, so the Demonic Cult bastards who charged in without knowing what they were walking into died in droves too. Do you know the Sichuan Tang Clan's motto?"

"Uh… 'The North Remembers'?"

"…What the hell are you talking about?"

[1708] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

"You know nothing, Gung Snow."[1709]

Gung Gibang looked at me as though he were staring at a madman before opening his mouth.

"Repay kindness twofold. Repay grudges ten thousandfold."

"Damn, that's intense."

"It was. The demonic, heterodox bastards who sided with the Demonic Cult during the occupation of Sichuan died shitting and pissing through all seven apertures."[1710]

"Poisoning?"

"Poisoning, assassination, and even sending out pursuit squads to hunt them down independently. They died in all sorts of ways. A few may have survived through sheer luck, but they probably weren't really living even if they were alive."

Understandable.

Could that person walking toward me be an assassin sent by the Tang Clan? Had they perhaps poisoned the teacup? Trapped in a prison created by psychological pressure, they would have suffered from nervous exhaustion for the rest of their life.

They probably spent their days trembling in a corner with a sword in one hand and a silver spoon in the other.

"When it comes to poison and hidden weapons, the Sichuan Tang Clan is number one under heaven. No one can match how closed-off and relentless they are. Did you see anyone from the Sichuan Tang Clan at the Star-Array Grand Banquet?"

Thinking back, I couldn't remember seeing a single one.

Even factions that hadn't sent their young prodigies to compete in the Star-Array Grand Banquet, such as the Namgung Family, had sent important figures. But I hadn't heard of anyone coming from the Sichuan Tang Clan.

"I don't think so."

"Right? There wasn't anyone?"

"No. There really wasn't."

"That's the Sichuan Tang Clan."

They do whatever the fuck they want. No brakes.

I could feel it. The more I listened, the more uneasy I became.

What if they turn us down flat?

I had even brought a letter from the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak to request their cooperation, but I couldn't shake the feeling that something might go wrong.

[1709] "The North Remembers" and "You know nothing, Jon Snow" are references to *Game of Thrones*; Taekyung substitutes Gung Gibang's name for Jon's.

[1710] The seven apertures are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

I was suppressing those thoughts and using my movement technique when Gung Gibang suddenly spoke.

“We should walk from here.”

“Do we really have to?”

“They probably won’t appreciate us approaching at high speed.”

“They might.”

Gung Gibang pointed at a massive boulder a few paces ahead.

Written across it in blood-red letters were the words:

> Anyone who approaches without permission will pay a blood debt.

“Let’s walk. I’ve been wanting to walk for a while now.”

“…”

“Hey, sometimes you need to look around at the scenery and gaze up at the sky. That’s what living is all about.”

Gung Gibang, Hyuk Mujin, and I stopped using our movement techniques.

One person did not.

With a fierce gust of wind, a figure shot straight toward the front gate.

Whoooosh!

“Hellooo!”

“Cheongpung, you crazy bastard!”

“I’m Cheongpung!”

Cheongpung hurtled forward, waving energetically, with a boy of similar build riding on his back.

Cheongpung spoke to Mungyeong, who was swaying pitifully in every direction.

“Medical apprentice, say hello!”

“H-Hello!”

Please don’t.

Don’t make him do weird things. And don’t do them just because he tells you to.

I lunged forward to grab Cheongpung by the scruff of his neck, but the Sichuan Tang Clan’s response came faster.

Whoooosh! Boom!

A massive spear as tall as a grown man hurtled down from atop the stone wall. It buried itself directly in front of Cheongpung’s foot, its shaft quivering.

Then, in the next instant—

“Who goes there?”

Clatter-clatter-clatter!

Dozens of crossbows appeared atop the wall along with the shout, which carried powerful internal energy.

Between the countless arrowheads glittering in the sunlight, a middle-aged man with his eyes wide open shouted at us again.

“Outsiders, identify yourselves!”

Cheongpung answered.

“Hello! I’m Cheongpung!”

“I-I am Mungyeong. P-please show mercy and lower your weapons, and I shall repay this grace even if this body dies and dies, then dies a hundred times over, until— Mmph!”

Stop it, you trolls!

I hurriedly clamped my hands over Cheongpung’s and Mungyeong’s mouths, then bowed repeatedly toward the wall.

“I’m sorry. I’m sorry. The kids don’t know any better. My name is Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

The middle-aged man thought for a moment, then his eyes widened slightly.

“Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi—the Disciple of Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King?”

“Yes. That’s me.”

I jerked my chin toward Gung Gibang, who had arrived a beat later, and continued.

“This is the Oseong-and-Haneum villain—no, the Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar, Gung Gibang.”[1711]

“The Disciple of Great Hero Jeok Cheongang and the Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar…”

His tone and expression remained suspicious, but the middle-aged man’s wariness eased considerably.

When he crooked a finger, the crossbows aimed at us lowered toward the ground.

“What brings you to our family?”

“I’d like to meet the Family Head.”

“The Family Head?”

“Yes. It’s important.”

The middle-aged man frowned, apparently displeased with my answer, but this wasn’t something we could announce to the whole neighborhood.

The Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was no fool. There was a reason he had written the letter himself and entrusted us to deliver it in person instead of sending a messenger pigeon.

[1711] Oseong and Haneum were famous Joseon-era friends whose names are commonly paired.

"The Family Head has many matters to handle right now. Our family is not accepting any outsiders whatsoever. Leave and return another time."

"You only need to deliver a message."

"Impossible. The Family Head himself gave me these orders. And if your business were truly that important, you should have contacted us in advance."

Why is he being so damn firm? I didn't plan for this.

Gung Gibang seemed to be thinking the same thing. He whispered in a voice as small as an ant.

"Something's strange. Even for a closed-off place like the Sichuan Tang Clan, this is too much…"

I agreed. Pointing crossbows at us without warning and maintaining this level of vigilance were things one would expect only in wartime.

What a warm welcome.

Still, we had come to ask for their cooperation. I couldn't simply complain. If we wanted to meet the Family Head, it seemed we would have to show at least half our hand, even if we didn't reveal everything.

Can't be helped.

After a brief hesitation, I stared straight at the middle-aged man.

"I brought a letter from Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint."

"…!"

"Please allow me to meet the Family Head."

The effect was immediate. The Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was an idol to martial artists and a giant among giants who might become the Alliance Leader of the New Murim Alliance.

He was in a completely different league from greenhorns like us, who had only made names for ourselves within the past year or two.

"…Hmm. Wait here a moment."

The middle-aged man let out a groan and disappeared from the top of the stone wall. He returned a short while later.

His first words were practically a foregone conclusion.

"The Family Head has granted permission."

The moment he finished speaking—

Grrrrrrr.

The enormous iron gate slowly opened its jaws with a grinding groan.

Not long after passing through the iron gate, I realized my earlier suspicion had been correct.

Something happened. There's no doubt about it.

The people who appeared to be members of the Sichuan Tang Clan were proof enough. Their guarded movements, tense eyes, and overall atmosphere said it all.

The sense that something was wrong grew even stronger after we left the Outer Hall and entered the Inner Hall.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Craftsmen hammered away at something without pause. Martial artists dressed in uniforms walked around in pairs, while crates loaded with weapons and hidden weapons were carried from place to place.

At the sight, Gung Gibang and I exchanged Sound Transmission.

— Hey, am I the only one getting a bad feeling?

— I feel it too. It looks like they're preparing for battle.

— Could they have found some demonic fiend? Maybe one of the men who set fire to the Sichuan Tang Clan during the Great Faction War.

— I don't know. For now, we should keep our mouths shut and pretend we don't know anything.

I had already been planning to do that. If they had intended to tell us, they would have done so by now.

The real problem was that only I had heard the Sound Transmission.

"Wow! I've never seen anything like this before! Are you preparing for a war or something?"

"…!"

"…!"

For a moment, I thought the world had stopped.

The craftsmen and martial artists around us froze in place and silently stared at us.

Hundreds of gazes pierced my entire body like hidden weapons.

What sin did I commit in my past life to get tangled up with a bastard like Cheongpung?

One second. Two seconds. Three seconds.

Is this the Hyperbolic Time Chamber?[1712]

By the time my mouth had dried out like the sand around the Sphinx's front paws, the middle-aged man guiding us spoke to the others.

"What are you doing? Get back to work."

Only then did the world begin moving again.

The middle-aged man glanced at the people returning to their tasks, then casually tossed a remark our way.

[1712] The Hyperbolic Time Chamber is a place in *Dragon Ball* where time passes differently from the outside world.

“You all look tight-lipped. I like that.”

On the surface, it sounded like a compliment.

So why did it sound like a warning to keep our mouths shut if we wanted to live long, healthy lives?

Why else? Because that’s exactly what he meant, damn it.

Maybe it was because of the Tang Clan’s association with poison and hidden weapons.

The middle-aged man and the other members of the Tang Family were clearly a step below me in skill, yet they all gave off an unmistakably dangerous scent.

“Hold your breath. That’s poison mist. It smells awful.”

“…Oh. Yes.”

So that was the dangerous smell?

I glared at the blue-haired bastard, who was still looking around with a bright expression, and continued walking behind the middle-aged man.

After walking for some time, we passed through five gates and finally stopped in front of the sixth.

“You cannot bring weapons into the Family Head’s Hall.”

Following the middle-aged man’s instructions, we handed over all our weapons. Afterward, the martial artists guarding the hall searched us as well.

They’re incredibly strict.

At that moment, one of the guards patting me down in search of hidden weapons suddenly flinched and shouted.

“There’s a hidden weapon here!”

“That’s not a hidden weapon. It’s my thing.”

“Pardon?”

“It’s mine. You know… that.”

“…!”

What kind of humiliation play is this?

I would rather pull out a poisoned hidden weapon than take that out in the Family Head’s Hall. It would be a much easier way to die.

I reluctantly gave him permission to see for himself, and the middle-aged man’s eyes widened.

“You’re quite impressive.”

“…Could you just let me through without saying anything?”

“I understand. But you really are impressive.”

“Oh, please.”

Reading the sincerity in my plea, he was about to order the guards to let us pass when he suddenly frowned.

“I nearly forgot. You there, stay behind.”

Oh, right. He was here.

The “you” the middle-aged man was referring to was Mungyeong.

“I hear you’re a medical apprentice who came to our family to obtain a prescription.”

Having been dragged this far before he even knew what was happening, Mungyeong answered in a trembling voice.

“Y-Yes.”

“Under normal circumstances, it would be out of the question… but you were fortunate enough to fall in with the right group. I’ll assign someone to guide you, so go take care of your business.”

“Th-Thank you.”

Mungyeong bowed deeply before disappearing with one of the martial artists. The middle-aged man took the lead and beckoned to us.

“Let us go inside.”

Twenty steps made of blue stone.

And at the top, a single door.

“Uncle, it’s me.”

An elderly voice answered the middle-aged man.

“Come in.”

Chapter 336

An old tree.

That was the first thing that came to mind when I saw the old man.

Inside the dark pavilion, partitioned off by cloth on all four sides, he stood alone with his back to us. He looked like an ancient tree that had lost every trace of life.

If he hadn't slowly turned around the next moment, I might have thought he had already taken root in the floor.

"I see…"

Green light swirled in his eyes.

The old man—Tang Sadok, the Myriad-Poison Asura[1713]—continued in a voice that hissed like a snake.

"You brought a letter?"

The middle-aged man answered.

"Yes, Uncle. Great Hero Mae Jonghak sent—"

"Did I ask you?"

"…!"

"This is no place for you. Leave."

Realizing his mistake, the middle-aged man bowed silently and left the pavilion.

After coldly dismissing his own nephew with a few words, Tang Sadok leaned back in a leather chair.

Would you look at the presence on this old man.

The problem was, it was a villain's presence.

From my first impression alone, I could have believed he belonged to the Demonic Cult rather than the orthodox faction.

I stepped forward beneath Tang Sadok's gaze.

"I am Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. It is an honor to meet you, Great Hero Tang Sadok."

Tang Sadok answered with an unreadable expression.

"I have heard that Senior Jeok took a Disciple in his later years. I also know of his ties to the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Oh, really?"

That was a good sign.

Tang Sadok stroked his chin in thought, then abruptly spoke.

"His name was… Yes, the Blade of Flowers, Jin Baekyang. Now I remember."

Good sign, my ass. That name pops up every time I'm about to forget it.

The Head Elder really must have been something in his day.

[1713] An *asura* is a powerful, often warlike being in Hindu and Buddhist traditions.

Then again, it made sense. He had been a Peak master who distinguished himself during the Great Faction War. It was hardly strange that he had formed friendships with other masters during that time.

He even said he'd met the Fire King once or twice.

Thanks to that, when I first met Jeok Cheongang, I got nailed with a Flame Divine Palm before I could explain the situation.

Tang Sadok stared at me and asked,

"How has Jin Baekyang been?"

"Well, you see…"

Before answering, I glanced around, ready to dodge in case a poisonous snake suddenly sprang out or a hidden weapon came flying at me.

"He passed away."

"What?"

Yeah, I knew this was coming.

Tang Sadok's eyes flew open, and I hurried to continue.

"It was an unfortunate accident. There were circumstances, of course. If you give me a little time, I can explain everything and clear up any misunderstandings—"

"No need."

"Excuse me?"

"He was an obnoxious bastard. Every time people fawned over him and called him a Great Hero or a chivalrous knight, it soured my mood."

"…"

"No martial artist dies without a reason. Once he is dead, that is the end of it."

I was relieved that this had gone more smoothly than expected, but the old man's personality was practically toxic.

Wasn't he basically saying he was glad the obnoxious bastard was dead?

His personality is practically on Dark Heaven's level.

Whether or not he sensed the suspicion taking root in my mind, Tang Sadok waved a hand irritably.

"Enough about the dead. Let us get to the point. Great Hero Mae Jonghak sent this old man a letter?"

"Yes. It'll be faster if you read it yourself."

I pretended to rummage through my robes and summoned the Sword Saint's handwritten letter from my Inventory.

Tang Sadok took the letter and read it. The furrows between his brows deepened until a furious roar finally burst from his throat.

"Those goddamn bastards!"

Whoooom!

The pavilion shuddered beneath the force of his profound internal energy.

His green robes billowed as his fury erupted, and he ground out each word as though chewing it up and spitting it out.

"Is everything written here true?"

"Yes. It happened exactly as the letter says."

The Sword Saint's letter clearly summarized the events in Henan and asked Tang Sadok to provide every possible assistance in finding the Divine Physician to treat Jeok Cheongang.

"To think Senior Jeok's condition is so grave…"

"Actually, there's something I'd like to ask before we begin searching for the Divine Physician."

The Sichuan Tang Clan was renowned throughout the martial world for its poisons and hidden weapons, but every member of the family was also a skilled physician.

And one among them stood at the very pinnacle.

I looked straight at Tang Sadok and asked,

"Could I meet the Grand Family Head?"

Poison King Tang Taesang.

A Supreme Peak master who had been called the greatest under heaven when it came to poisons and hidden weapons, even before the Great Faction War.

After dominating an entire era, he had passed the position of Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan to his only child twenty years ago and disappeared from public view.

That child was the old man standing before me now—Tang Sadok.

"We have no idea how many days it might take to find the Divine Physician. If the Poison King could examine my Master before then…"

"Enough."

Tang Sadok cut me off, his face rigid.

"Impossible. That is this old man's answer."

"…!"

My heart sank at the unexpected response.

Poison King Tang Taesang might not have appeared in public for many years, but Tang Sadok clearly knew where he was.

Impossible. Tang Sadok knew, yet he was still refusing to help.

My voice trembled despite myself.

"W-Why?"

"I cannot say."

"You cannot say?"

"Instead, I will assign several people to guide you. If you go to Qingcheng and Emei, they will gladly help you."

What did I just hear?

This shock was several times greater than the first.

Tang Sadok's words meant the Sichuan Tang Clan would not help us with this matter.

Well, it wasn't as though they were offering no help whatsoever.

A few guides to take us to the Qingcheng Sect and Emei Sect.

That was it.

That was all the help we could expect from the Sichuan Tang Clan.

The back of my head tingled as though someone had clubbed me with an iron rod. Something hot surged up from deep within my chest.

"Is that all?"

"What more did you expect?"

"We need to find the Divine Physician!"

"That is your problem, not mine or our family's. The fact that you brought a letter from Great Hero Mae Jonghak changes nothing. It was a request, and this old man refused it. That is all."

The words lodged in my throat.

Everything Tang Sadok said was true. To him and the Sichuan Tang Clan, helping us was a choice, not an obligation.

Right. Of course it was.

Once I finally accepted the truth I had kept desperately denying, bitter disappointment and anger welled up inside me.

As I stood there at a loss for words, someone stepped forward with the sweet scent of snacks.

"I am Cheongpung of Huashan. It is an honor to meet you."

So he had this side to him too.

Wearing an expression I had never seen before and speaking in an unfamiliar tone, Cheongpung offered a clasped-fist salute[1714] and continued.

"I do not know why you are refusing, Family Head, but if you help us, I will never forget this kindness."

"I know you are Great Hero Mae Jonghak's Disciple. One must be cautious when forming ties of gratitude and grudges[1715] in the martial world. Stop meddling in matters that do not concern you and step back."

"I'm not meddling."

"Then what are you doing?"

Cheongpung answered with a clear, unwavering gaze.

"My grandfather called it human compassion."

"…!"

[1714] A traditional greeting made by bringing one fist against the opposite open palm.

[1715] In the martial world, kindness and harm create moral debts that must be repaid.

Tang Sadok regarded Cheongpung with a complicated expression, then shook his head.

“Even if Great Hero Mae Jonghak came here and asked me himself, this old man’s answer would remain the same.”

“But…”

Cheongpung, Gung Gibang, and Hyuk Mujin all started to speak at once, but I cut in first.

“What’s the reason?”

“The reason?”

“Even a stray mutt passing by knows how powerful the Sichuan Tang Clan is. So why the hell are you refusing?”

“And what will you do if I do not wish to tell you?”

“What will I do?”

I stared into Tang Sadok’s green eyes and answered,

“Then the ties of gratitude and grudges[1716] you mentioned will form between me and the Sichuan Tang Clan. And I should warn you—they won’t be the pleasant kind.”

“Hah. What a fearless brat.”

“Normally, I check where I’m lying before I stretch out my legs, but in this case, I’m in a bit—well, a lot—of a hurry.”

Jeok Cheongang had half a year left at most.

Even the greatest martial sects under heaven and the Imperial Court had failed to find the Divine Physician.

If Jeok Cheongang died because he could not receive treatment in time… If he died because the Sichuan Tang Clan had refused to help…

“Then I don’t know what I might do.”

When I finished speaking, suffocating silence descended upon the pavilion.

Tang Sadok studied me for a long time, his gaze deep and unfathomable. At last, his lips parted.

“I regret what happened to Senior Jeok.”

“If you’re sorry, why not help us?”

“This old man would like to. But what can I do? Our family does not have the strength to spare right now.”

No strength to spare?

The moment I heard those words, the scenes I had witnessed on the way here flashed through my mind.

[1716] In the martial world, kindness and harm create moral debts that must be repaid.

An atmosphere so tense it bordered on murderous. Artisans working without rest. Weapons constantly being carried from one place to another.

“What the hell is going on?”

“Going on?”

Step.

Tang Sadok took a step toward me.

Perhaps it was due to the poison arts he had cultivated, but his green eyes gleamed more eerily than ever. Within them burned anger and grief.

“It has already happened. All that remains now is for our family to marshal its full strength and slaughter every last culprit involved.”

That was it.

That was why the Sichuan Tang Clan could not help us now.

That was why Tang Sadok had been so reluctant to explain himself, even after a green brat like me challenged him to his face.

That was why this took priority over finding the Divine Physician and saving the Fire King’s life—and why he had flatly refused to let me meet Poison King Tang Taesang.

“Don’t tell me…”

Perhaps he saw the realization on my face.

Tang Sadok met my wide-eyed stare and spoke in a voice thick with killing intent.

“By the time we received the news, it was already too late. Not one of his limbs had been left intact.”

Those words turned my suspicion into certainty.

Poison King Tang Taesang was dead.

“Hmm.”

The middle-aged man was of average height, with a round face and the sort of ordinary appearance one might see anywhere.

Leaning against the wall of a pitch-black cave, he carefully examined his forearm and muttered.

“This won’t do. The poison is vicious.”

He clicked his tongue softly.

He had done everything he could, but the best he had managed was to force all the poison into one arm.

“Poison King… He was fierce. More than I expected.”

Poison King Tang Taesang.

The expression on his face when he finally breathed his last was still vivid in the middle-aged man's mind.

But the result left the middle-aged man in a difficult position.

He had succeeded in eliminating the Supreme Peak master known as the Poison King, yet failed to accomplish the more important task.

Not that I ever expected it to be easy.

With that thought, the middle-aged man abruptly brought the edge of his hand down on his left forearm.

A dazzling flash burst forth, and the severed forearm fell to the ground.

Schhk! Ssssss!

Poison-laden blood splattered across the cave, melting everything it touched. Acrid toxic smoke billowed into the air.

The small creatures watching the middle-aged man from hidden crevices died the instant the smoke reached them, never knowing what had happened.

Eek… Eeeek…

Listening to the bats' dying shrieks, the middle-aged man walked out of the cave and grinned up at the blazing sunlight.

It was impossible to believe that smile belonged to a man who had just cut off his own arm.

Chapter 337

Inside the vast, chilly pavilion, a draft squeezed through the gaps around the windows, making the oil lamp on the windowsill flicker. An old man's face slowly appeared over the wavering flame.

Eyes suffused with green light and a body as withered as an ancient tree.

The old man's name was Tang Sadok. His alias was the Myriad-Poison Asura.

He was the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, one of the Five Great Families under heaven—and a son who had recently lost his father.

Whoooosh.

The cold wind beating against the closed window seemed to carry the voice I had heard several shichen[1717] ago.

By the time I heard the news, it was already too late. Not one of his limbs had been left intact.

The One God, the Three Saints, and the Ten Kings.

The heroes who had once saved the world from the hundred thousand forces of the Demonic Path had long since become white-haired old men.

Some had grown old or sick and died. Some had vanished after seeking peace. Others had handed their successors the responsibility and stepped down.

Poison King Tang Taesang had also left to find his own path.

There is a place called Meishan two days from here. My father often spoke of its beautiful mountains.

More than twenty years ago, it had only been natural for the Poison King to head for Meishan after stepping down as Family Head.

It must have been the final resting place chosen by an old martial artist who had spent his entire life weathering the turbulent currents of Murim.

He did not welcome visitors. We had no choice but to send someone to check on him every once in a while.

And that had become a scar that would never fade.

Several days ago, an unbelievable urgent report had arrived.

When Tang Sadok rushed there in a panic, he found the aftermath of a battle that had shaken heaven and earth—and the Poison King's corpse.

"My father's body had been… severely mutilated. They were unmistakable signs of torture."

I did not know why the culprit had tortured the Poison King.

But Poison King Tang Taesang, a Supreme Peak master who had dominated an entire era, had died that way. At the hands of an unknown figure whose name and face remained a mystery.

[1717] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Furious beyond measure, Tang Sadok had personally led his clansmen in combing the surrounding area, but it was already too late.

I will find that bastard and kill him. I'll tear his limbs apart and scatter them across the Nine Provinces, then let the blood from his body flow into the Four Seas and Five Lakes.

What could anyone say to Tang Sadok as he raged, radiating suffocating killing intent? I understood his anger and resolve well enough.

He and the Sichuan Tang Clan would never stop until they found the culprit and killed him. Naturally, they could not help us find the Divine Physician.

"Poison King Tang Taesang is dead. The Poison King himself…"

A massive tectonic shift was taking place. And it was happening right beside us.

Just as I murmured those words while staring at the oil lamp, an urgent voice came from behind me.

"Watch your mouth. Do you have any idea what'll happen if you say something like that in the middle of the Sichuan Tang Clan?"

It was not difficult to tell who the voice belonged to. I had sensed the three of them approaching long ago.

Without turning my head, I answered, "You're back."

"Not 'you're back.' I said watch your mouth. Your mouth!"

"It's fine. There's no one nearby."

"I'm saying we should be careful. Being around you scares the life out of me."

Gung Gibang sighed and dropped into a chair. Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin entered behind him and each claimed a seat.

"Where did you go?"

Gung Gibang answered curtly.

"The Chengdu branch of the Beggars' Sect."

"Mungyeong went with you?"

"Of course not. He's holed up in the pavilion the Tang Clan provided for him. When I saw him earlier, he was so absorbed in a medicinal prescription that he didn't even notice someone had come in. He'll probably stay the night and leave with us tomorrow."

"So? Did you find anything out?"

"No. It was a waste of time. I casually probed the branch leader about the Sichuan Tang Clan, but he didn't know much either."

That was understandable. From what I had heard, the Poison King's residence lay deep in a remote mountain valley that no one ever visited. Only a member of Tang Sadok's household would secretly stop by every once in a while.

Besides, the Sichuan Tang Clan deliberately covered everything up…

Tang Sadok wanted his family to take revenge on its own.

Considering the power possessed by the Sichuan Tang Clan, a great Murim family, and the character they had displayed, their independent course of action was not strange at all.

“He did find it a little suspicious. Apparently, the Sichuan Tang Clan recently sent people to request some information they needed.”

“They’ve already caught the scent. Did you tell him?”

Gung Gibang hesitated for a moment before speaking.

“Although Great Hero Tang Sadok ordered everyone to remain silent… I’m the Successor Beggar of the Beggars’ Sect. I told the branch leader the truth and instructed him to keep an eye on anyone suspicious.”

“What about Cheongpung?”

Amid the serious atmosphere, Cheongpung was struggling mightily to suppress a yawn.

“I sent a messenger eagle to my grandfather, just as my Benefactor instructed.”

Gung Gibang nodded and added, “The message will reach him within seven days at the latest.”

“Good. Well done.”

I thought we had taken the bare minimum of precautions.

Tang Sadok would be furious if he found out, but this was something I had to do.

“Um, Captain.”

“Hmm?”

Hyuk Mujin glanced around cautiously before speaking.

“May I ask you something?”

“If I say no, will you refrain from asking?”

“No. You know I can’t stand not knowing something.”

“…”

I was already so troubled that I could die from it, and this idiot was unbelievable.

For a moment, I considered giving him a good, satisfying smack for the first time in a while, but held myself back.

“What is it?”

“Why are you clenching your fist? That’s scary.”

“Stop stalling and ask, you bastard.”

Hyuk Mujin eyed my fist warily and whispered, “Who’s the culprit?”

“The culprit?”

“Yes. The culprit who killed and even tortured Great Hero Tang Taesang, the Poison King.”

“Well, well. The culprit.”

Smack!

“Argh! Why did you hit me?”

“If I, knew, would I, be here, doing this? Huh?”

Smack! Smack! Smack! Smack!

I pummeled the back of his head without holding back. It was wonderfully cathartic.

“Ugh… If you didn’t know, you could’ve just said so. Why…”

“Because you’re spouting nonsense and pissing me off.”

“Th-that’s…”

Gung Gibang looked contemptuously at Hyuk Mujin as he thrashed around, clutching his head.

“Tsk, tsk. Even a stray yellow dog is wiser than you. How would anyone know who that heinous bastard is or where he came from?”

Hyuk Mujin wiped away a stray tear and muttered, “You spread a mat beside that stray yellow dog and beg in the street.”

“What did you say?!”

“Why? Am I wrong?”

“How dare you insult our Sect!”

“They say you should call a spade a spade. Don’t misunderstand—I only look down on you, Young Hero Gung.”

Cheongpung burst out laughing and clapped.

“Wow! Benefactor! Young Hero Hyuk said he looks down on Young Hero Gung!”

“Don’t laugh! Stop him, you lunatic Cheongpung!”

Hyuk Mujin had gotten much better with his words.

I held back Gung Gibang, who looked ready to explode after that brutal dose of truth.

“Both of you, calm down.”

That did not seem sufficient, so I added one more thing.

“Unless you want me to beat you to death.”

“…”

“…”

That was better.

I let out a deep sigh as I watched them glower and huff at each other.

“Who knows what kind of bastard the culprit is? If we knew, the Sichuan Tang Clan would’ve caught and killed him already.”

Still glaring, Hyuk Mujin said, “I know that. I mean, do you have any guesses?”

“Think before you ask. Think, you foolish bastard.”

“But when did we become close enough for you to keep speaking informally to me? Does being the Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar give you the right to look

down on the Vice Squad Leader of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan's Jin Dragon Squad? Don't you agree, Captain?"

…Actually, given the difference between them, it did seem reasonable for him to look down on Mujin.

When I did not answer, Hyuk Mujin's eyes narrowed.

I subtly changed the subject.

"Well, Murim is crawling with suspicious bastards. There are the Dark Heaven and Demonic Cult bastards, for starters."

"Hmph! Do you think they're the only possibilities?"

Gung Gibang snorted harshly and picked up the thread.

"The Sichuan Tang Clan has devoted all its strength to eliminating demonic, heterodox arts. It could have been someone with a personal grudge."

I stared in disgust at the booger stuck to the bridge of Gung Gibang's nose.

"Weren't those demonic and heterodox bastards wiped out already?"

"No matter how thoroughly you sweep a courtyard, some sand always remains. The world is vast. Do you really think there was nowhere for them to hide? Some survived to the bitter end despite the relentless pursuit."

That was a valid point.

And if they had survived being hunted by the orthodox faction that ruled Murim, every last one of them had to be an incredible master.

Like the Yin-Yang Twin Freaks I fought at Shaolin.

Who could have imagined that two Supreme Peak fiends believed to be dead would appear at Shaolin?

Murim was a place where countless chains of gratitude and grudges became tangled together. No matter what happened or where, nothing was truly surprising.

And there was the torture.

There were two reasons to torture someone.

Either you hated them enough to make them suffer before killing them, or there was something you wanted them to tell you.

I did not know the culprit's purpose, but one thing was certain.

…One seriously dangerous bastard has appeared.

And he was someone I did not want to encounter, even by chance.

My current realm was at the very edge of Peak. I had not yet attained enlightenment, but with the power I had obtained through the System, I could hold my own against someone who had just entered Supreme Peak.

Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword, was a perfect example.

But an opponent beyond that level would be difficult. In fact, if I had not gained a small insight during my battle with Hwangbo Eom, I might have been forced to kneel before his Taeeul Formless Sword.

And if my opponent was powerful enough to kill the Poison King, who had ranked among the five strongest of the Ten Kings…

As I am now, defeat would be certain.

As much as it pained me, I had no choice but to accept that reality.

While I was quietly lost in thought, Gung Gibang suddenly spoke as if something had just occurred to him.

“Come to think of it, the culprit could be an assassin.”

“A killer? An assassin?”

“Are there other kinds of assassins?”

I frowned.

“You think those bastards are that skilled?”

“You don’t know what you’re talking about. According to my Master, the Valley Master of Moonshadow Assassination Valley has killed no fewer than three Supreme Peak masters.”

“…An assassin killed three Supreme Peak masters?”

“Without a doubt. I heard it threw the entire Murim into an uproar.”

“Then is that Valley Master or whatever the greatest assassin under heaven?”

Gung Gibang looked at me as though I were the most insane person alive.

“What are you talking about? The greatest assassin under heaven has never changed.”

“Oh.”

I had momentarily forgotten.

The Sword Saint. The Bow Saint. And finally, the man known as the Slaughter Saint.

When I first heard the name, I thought he was called the Slaughter Saint simply because he’d killed so many people.

As it turned out, being an assassin was his actual profession.

According to Jeok Cheongang, he had taken more lives than anyone could count. He killed people from the orthodox, demonic, and heterodox factions alike, so fairly and impartially that he had even been branded an enemy of all Murim.

That was until the Great Faction War.

He had killed so many demonic fiends that people had no choice but to issue an amnesty decree for the man who had once been an enemy of all Murim—and give him the alias Slaughter Saint.

“Of course, there’s no way the Slaughter Saint killed Great Hero Tang Taesang, but the Sichuan Tang Clan is probably considering the possibility that an assassin did it.”

“It’s unfortunate, but they’ll deal with it themselves.”

Whoever the culprit was, I had only one goal: find the Divine Physician and save Jeok Cheongang.

It was unfortunate that we could not receive help from the Sichuan Tang Clan, but Qingcheng and Emei still remained.

Which meant…

“Young Hero Gung, did you pull that booger out in advance so you could eat it as a late-night snack?”

“What did you say?!”

“Wahahaha! Benefactor! Young Hero Gung is going to eat his booger as a late-night snack!”

…No, seriously. What the hell was wrong with these bastards?

Unable to take it any longer, I overturned the table.

“Get the hell out! We have to leave early tomorrow, so go get some damn sleep!”

I unleashed a lion’s roar and chased the Bermuda Triangle away, then dropped back into my chair.

I stared blankly at the flickering oil lamp before murmuring, “Inventory open. Summon.”

Tap.

A small jade-colored shard appeared in my palm.

When I turned over the **Divine Physician’s Token**, faint writing appeared.

> The finest Chinese gallnuts come from Sichuan.

Chinese gallnut, my ass. They should’ve written down the damn home address.

Chapter 338

That night, my mind was so full of worries that I never made it to bed. All I could do was watch the sun come up.

My body isn't tired, but my mind is.

Looking back, I had been through every kind of upheaval imaginable over the past few months.

If I hadn't kept my body and mind clear by circulating my qi, I might have developed stress-induced hair loss.

I had considered crossing over to reality for a while to rest, but a crazy skeleton mage was running wild over there.

Come to think of it, that place is in Sichuan too.

Was some kind of curse following me?

No wonder Shu was the first kingdom to fall in *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*.

Feeling vaguely uneasy, I left the pavilion with the pack frame on my back. The Bermuda Triangle was already outside waiting for me.

"Oh? The booger's gone. Did you really eat it as a late-night snack?"

"Stop! I said stop!"

"Benefactor! Benefactor! Gung Gibang ate that booger last night!"

"I did not!"

"…"

Ugh. I wanted to beat every last one of them to death.

If this were a novel and I were the author, I would find some way to kill those bastards.

But when did anything in this world ever go the way I wanted? I was shaking my head when—

"*Huff, huff.* I'm sorry I'm late!"

Right. There was that guy too.

Mungyeong came running up, panting heavily.

"Huff… I-I stayed up late reading medicinal prescriptions, and…"

I didn't even have to look. I could see the whole thing in virtual reality: he had clearly pushed himself too hard in his burning enthusiasm for learning, then overslept.

I waved off Mungyeong as he anxiously watched my expression.

"It's fine. I just came out too. By the way, you've picked up quite a bit of luggage overnight."

"Oh, this?"

Mungyeong smiled brightly and patted his bulging travel bag.

“They gave me copies of some precious medicinal prescriptions and plenty of medicinal herbs, and—and… Anyway, they gave me all sorts of things!”

“Good. Congratulations.”

“Hehe.”

That kid was absolutely thrilled.

Then again, to a novice medical apprentice like Mungyeong, all of this was practically a fortuitous encounter.

The Sichuan Tang Clan wasn’t the kind of place that opened its doors to anyone who knocked, much less freely handed over medicinal prescriptions.

It was a great Murim family as well as a renowned medical family. Everything Mungyeong had gained here would be a tremendous asset to him in the future.

“Good. You should be able to take something away from this, at least.”

“Huh?”

“Never mind.”

“Did things not go well for you?”

“Yeah. There’s someone who absolutely has to be treated, but… circumstances are making it difficult.”

We were still talking when the middle-aged man we had met the day before approached with several subordinates.

“Everyone’s here. Follow me.”

We followed him. The atmosphere and behavior of the people we passed seemed even more tense than yesterday, but there were far fewer martial artists around.

It’s begun.

Large numbers of martial artists must have left to hunt down the culprit.

No, the hunt had probably begun before we even arrived. Tang Sadok had lost his father. There was no way he would have spent several days sitting around in a daze.

After walking while lost in thought, we soon reached the iron gate.

As the gate slowly opened, the middle-aged man abruptly spoke.

“Uncle—no, the Family Head asked me to deliver a message.”

“What did he say?”

“Once his revenge is complete, our family will help you with all its strength.”

Mungyeong looked confused, but everyone else, myself included, offered a clasped-fist salute.

“May you achieve what you seek.”

“And you as well.”

A faint smile crossed the middle-aged man’s cold face.

We hadn’t received any practical assistance, but this was a decent enough farewell.

Now it was time to say goodbye to one more person.

“It’s been fun.”

Mungyeong nodded as though he understood.

“You’re leaving again.”

“Yeah. We have a lot of places to stop by.”

“If I may ask, where are you going…?”

“Qingcheng. Then Emei.”

Mungyeong’s eyes widened.

“Oh! Mount Qingcheng and Mount Emei, two of the most famous mountains under heaven! You don’t mean the sacred sites of Daoism and Buddhism, where all manner of exotic flowers and mystical herbs are said to be hidden?”

“…Uh, I think those are the ones.”

“I can’t believe it! You’re going somewhere that wonderful!”

What was this? Déjà vu?

I felt as if I had been seeing this same scene a lot lately. Just as a strange sense of foreboding sent a chill down my spine, Mungyeong let out a soft sigh.

“It’s a shame, but I can’t go with you this time. I have to return to my master.”

“Nice one, Master!”

“…?”

“I mean, that’s too bad.”

“Riiight.”

“I mean it, you punk.”

Mungyeong gave me a suspicious look, then bowed deeply.

“Thank you for everything. Thanks to all you Young Masters, I survived and had so many wonderful experiences.”

“There’s no need to thank me. Stay healthy, study hard, and focus on becoming a great physician.”

Mungyeong’s eyes sparkled.

“Like the Divine Physician?”

“Exactly. Like the Divine Physician.”

“Yes, Young Master! I’ll engrave your words on my heart and never forget them!”

A quiet laugh escaped me at his spirited answer.

“Take care, then.”

“Goodbye! We have to meet again someday!”

If fate brought us together again, we would meet one way or another.

I waved to Mungyeong, then turned resolutely toward the west.

“Come on. Let’s go to Qingcheng.”

I was just about to take my first determined step when—

“Young Hero Jin Taekyung?”

“Hm?”

I looked back and saw the Bermuda Triangle standing there blankly beside two unfamiliar men.

They were the guides the Sichuan Tang Clan had assigned to us.

“What is it?”

“Um, well…”

“…?”

“That’s not the right direction. The road is blocked if you go that way.”

“…!”

The guides Tang Sadok had assigned us proved to be a stroke of genius.

Unusually for members of the Tang Clan, they specialized in gathering and cultivating medicinal and poisonous herbs rather than martial arts. Perhaps because of that, they knew the land of Sichuan like the backs of their hands.

“We go this way from here, right?”

“No. That way is faster.”

“But according to the map, this seems to be the right way.”

“What’s written on a map isn’t always the answer. That’s especially true of old maps.”

“The Sichuan Tang Clan gave me this one.”

“I drew that map twenty years ago.”

“…”

“Let’s go.”

Well, if the mapmaker said it was the wrong way, then it was the wrong way.

After that, I simply went wherever they told me and stopped whenever they told me. Of course, I wasn’t just following them around doing nothing.

“Wait. Can’t we just jump across here?”

“Huh? This is a cliff.”

“If we jump straight to the cliff on the other side, we’ll get there in no time.”

“You’ll die in no time too. The gap is nearly twenty zhang[1718] wide. How could you possibly—”

“Come on, let’s give it a try.”

Boom! Whoooosh! Tap-tap!

“See? It works.”

[1718] A zhang is a traditional unit of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Twenty zhang is about 61 m (200 ft).

"…It actually works."

"All right, cross one at a time!"

"…Are you talking to us?"

"Oh."

"Could you jump back over and carry us across?"

"Can do. Easily."

I was willing to do anything if it would save time.

Combine Made-in-Sichuan navigation with monstrous physical abilities that far exceeded human limits, and wherever I went became a road.

"My goodness… This is impossible. It only took half a day to get from Chengdu to Mount Qingcheng. The journey normally takes three days."

"Impossible is nothing."[1719]

I tossed out a famous line I had picked up from television as we entered Mount Qingcheng.

After revealing our identities to the disciples of the Qingcheng Sect, we were escorted to Shangqing Palace, where the sect decided all matters great and small. There, we met another Supreme Peak master: the Sect Leader of the Qingcheng Sect, Cheongpung the Ancient Sword.

"I'm Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Wow, hello! I'm Cheongpung! I've never met anyone with a name so similar to mine before. It's so nice to meet you!"

"Please shut up… And Cheongpung the Ancient Sword isn't his name. It's his alias."

The Elders of the Qingcheng Sect stared at us as if they had never seen such lunatics in their lives, but their Sect Leader, Cheongpung the Ancient Sword, proved far more straightforward than I had expected.

After reading the letter I handed him, he chuckled like a friendly old man from the neighborhood.

"We should help one another. Besides, Great Hero Mae Jonghak personally asked this favor of us."

That evening, the residents at the foot of Mount Qingcheng were thrown into an uproar.

Daoists from the Qingcheng Sect, whom they were lucky to see even a few times a year, came streaming down the mountain in a long procession.

There were hundreds of them. Among their number were the Qingcheng Seventy-Two Swordsmen, all First Rate masters, as well as two Elders.

"Our Sect Leader Senior Brother ordered us to do our utmost to help Young Hero Jin find the Divine Physician."

[1719] "Impossible Is Nothing" is an Adidas advertising slogan.

“Junior Brother and I have been nothing but old men gathering dust for years, but we’ll gladly step forward for something like this. Ho ho.”

Thank you. Overwhelming thanks…

Honestly, I couldn’t help getting a little choked up.

We might all belong to the orthodox faction, but an entire sect had rolled up its sleeves to save Jeok Cheongang.

“I will repay the Qingcheng Sect for this help.”

“I’ll hear that again after we find the Divine Physician.”

“And this isn’t all. We’ve also sent messenger pigeons to our lay disciples, so we should receive good news soon.”

Although the Qingcheng Sect did not possess the same standing as Huashan or Shaolin, it was still a massive, prestigious sect—large enough to be called one of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

The vast web of connections it had formed through its lay disciples would be an enormous help.

“Thank you. Truly, thank you.”

“A man shouldn’t bend his back so readily. We’re merely doing what we ought to do, so pay it no mind.”

“That’s right. Too much gratitude is unsightly. Enough with the formalities. Tell us where we should begin looking.”

I rubbed at the corners of my reddened eyes and answered.

“Everywhere.”

“Huh?”

“What?”

“All of Sichuan…”

“…!”

“…!”

After a brief silence, quiet mutters slipped from the lips of the two old Daoists who looked like immortals.

“Goddamn it…”

“How are we supposed to find him…?”

Leaving behind the two Daoists, who had begun succumbing to the woes of the secular world less than fifteen minutes after descending the mountain, I set off toward our next destination.

“Benefactor! Are we going to Mount Emei now?”

“No. Gung and Mujin will handle the Emei Sect.”

We had two guides, and there were already plenty of people in our group. There was no need for everyone to travel in one huge crowd.

There was no telling where Cheongpung might run off to, so I would keep him with me. By now, Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin were probably running as fast as they could toward the Emei Sect.

Just then, one of the guides asked curiously,

“Then where are you going?”

“To the authorities.”

“The authorities? You mean you’re going to a government office?”

“Yes.”

“Young Hero Jin, I don’t know what connections you have with the authorities, but this isn’t something you can accomplish by mobilizing a few constables.”

“Right.”

“Then why…?”

I spoke to the guide, who shook his head as though he could not understand me at all.

“But wouldn’t it be a different story with hundreds or thousands of people?”

“H-Hundreds or thousands? Are you perhaps acquainted with the Sichuan City Lord?”

“No.”

I grinned and continued.

“I’m friends with a king.”

“Pardon?”

Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao.

He was the one and only younger brother of the emperor of the Great Nation that ruled the world, a noble imperial Prince—and a huge fan of mine.

Chapter 339

Early morning.

Nestled in the arms of his favorite concubine, the City Lord of Sichuan Province asked groggily, “Who is it? Who’s here to see me?”

Confronted with his superior’s naked body first thing in the morning, the Captain of the Guards hurriedly lowered his gaze.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and a man named Cheongpung of Huashan request an audience.”

“Huashan?”

The name was fairly familiar.

Though he had been born into a powerful aristocratic family and lived a life entirely removed from Murim, even the City Lord of Sichuan had heard of Huashan more than once.

“Huashan… Isn’t that one of those Ten Great Sects or whatever they’re called?”

“More precisely, they are known as the Nine Sects and One Gang. Huashan is a prestigious sect renowned throughout Murim.”

“They’re still nothing but ruffians. Calling men who swing swords in broad daylight without so much as an identification plaque a prestigious sect… Tsk, tsk.”

The Captain of the Guards had once roamed the martial world himself. He had plenty to say, but antagonizing the City Lord would not be wise.

The City Lord clicked his tongue at the silent captain, then suddenly spoke again.

“Wait. The Jin Family of Taiyuan sounds rather familiar too.”

“It is an emerging sect that unified the Murim of Shanxi two years ago and has now made its name known throughout the Central Plains. Of course, if we are speaking only of the family’s history, it is old enough to rival the Nine Sects and One Gang…”

“No, that’s not what I mean. I’ve definitely heard the name plenty of times… Ah!”

After frowning in thought for a moment, the City Lord slapped his knee with a cry of realization.

“That’s right. The Jin Family Escort Bureau!”

“The Jin Family Escort Bureau…”

Only then did the Captain of the Guards recall what he had momentarily forgotten.

Come to think of it, it had not been that long ago. Three or four months at most. The sight of wagons laden with riches rolling in one after another had stretched the City Lord’s smile from ear to ear.

“But weren’t they the Jin Family Trading Company?”

“The Jin Family Escort Bureau and the Jin Family Trading Company. Both belong to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, if I remember correctly. Yes, it’s all coming back to me.”

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had entered the world of commerce in earnest by opening new trade routes through the northern tribes. Before long, its name had begun spreading throughout the Central Plains.

“So, what have they brought this time?”

The Captain of the Guards hesitated beneath the City Lord’s expectant gaze.

“Well… they appear to have come empty-handed.”

“What?”

“However, the young man named Jin Taekyung is a direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and a young prodigy who has earned great fame in Murim…”

“Enough of that martial-world nonsense.”

The City Lord was already scowling.

Born into an aristocratic family, he had noble pride ingrained in his very bones.

If the Jin Family Trading Company had come bearing bribes, he would have welcomed them with open arms. But some young brat claiming to be the direct descendant of a frontier martial family and requesting a private audience at the crack of dawn was another matter entirely.

No need to hear him out. He’s obviously here to ask for some filthy favor. This is why you shouldn’t accept things from lowborn people so readily.

Having already decided they were unwelcome guests, the City Lord pulled the blanket up to his chin.

“Damn it. I finally got a good night’s sleep, and now my mood is ruined.”

At that moment, his favorite concubine stirred awake and asked in a seductive voice, “My lord, what has you so upset?”

“Some young brat showed up at the crack of dawn. You remember the Jin Family Trading Company that came by a few months ago, don’t you, Aehyang?”

“Oh my. Yes, yes. Of course I do.”

“He says he’s a direct descendant of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, a pack of martial-world ruffians from Shanxi.”

“And?”

“What do you mean, ‘and’? He’s obviously here to ask for some dirty favor, so I should throw him out immediately. How dare he…”

“My lord.”

“What is it?”

“Why don’t you meet him just this once?”

“W-What?”

“He might have brought another nice gift. Like this pretty necklace I’m wearing.”

The City Lord’s heart melted at his concubine’s coy smile.

Just as she said, many of the items the Jin Family Trading Company had brought last time had been rare treasures.

The various pieces of jewelry and ornaments said to have been made by the northern tribes were mysterious yet exquisitely crafted. His concubine wore them constantly and never took them off.

“It’s my request. Won’t you grant it? Please?”

Favorite concubine launches three seconds of pleading gaze!

It was super effective!

The City Lord of Sichuan frantically waved to the Captain of the Guards.

“Bring them in. Quickly!”

“Yes. Shall I escort them to the reception room?”

“What reception room? I’ll only be seeing their faces for a moment. Bring them here.”

“…”

“What are you waiting for? Hurry up and bring in those martial-world ruffians.”

The Captain of the Guards bowed with a sour expression and left the room. The City Lord thrust out his protruding belly and put on airs for his concubine.

“I’m only agreeing to meet them as a special favor because you asked.”

“Thank you, my lord. But I heard those martial-world ruffians are terribly rough… Aehyang is scared.”

“What? Scared?”

The City Lord burst into hearty laughter, then declared in a deliberately stern voice, “Ho! I govern an entire city by the command of His Imperial Majesty himself. Are you saying you fear a few common street thugs?”

“Oh my. My lord, you’re so wonderful!”

The City Lord embraced the concubine nestled against him and smiled contentedly.

“Don’t worry about a thing. The moment those bastards enter, I’ll force them to their knees so they cannot even look at you.”

“Th-That’s…!”

Patter-patter-patter—thud!

The naked City Lord bolted out of bed, threw himself flat on the floor, and cried out, “I-I behold the token of His Highness Prince Shangshan!”

Good grief. Did he cook a locomotive smokestack rare and eat it?

His reaction was so extreme that even I was momentarily taken aback.

All I had done was take *that* out and show it to him.

Was it really that powerful?

I looked down at the gold plaque in my hand.

It had been about a year ago, if I remembered correctly. I had even held a private autograph session for Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao, and received this Item as a Quest completion Reward.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Prince Shangshan's Token
Type: Treasure
Grade: None
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Description: A token imbued with the authority of Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao, the emperor's only younger brother and an imperial prince. The clouds and dragon engraved into its surface symbolize the imperial family, and it is also of immense artistic value.
Special Note: Can be used only once.

I never expected to use something I had shoved into my Inventory and forgotten about like this.

I had known the imperial family wielded enormous authority in this world, but the City Lord's reaction exceeded even my expectations.

It's a shame I can only use it once.

Still, I couldn't complain.

I decided to give Prince Shangshan even better fan service from now on.

Next time I see him, I'll give him a rare collectible and even throw in a free hug.

When I remained silent, the City Lord cautiously raised his upper body.

At first, he had looked at Cheongpung and me as though we were street thugs. Now his eyes were trembling as though an earthquake had struck.

Wobble, wobble.

"…"

No, seriously. That did not need to be shaking too.

At my disgusted glare, the City Lord hurriedly covered his lower body.

"Th-There's a reason for this…"

There probably was.

Spring flowers were beginning to bloom outside, but the smell of chestnut blossoms[1720] was overpowering in here.

I picked up a blanket lying nearby and tossed it to him.

"Th-Thank you."

[1720] The scent of chestnut blossoms is used here as a euphemism for the smell of semen.

"Don't mention it."

If anything, I was the grateful one. Looking at a naked middle-aged man who appeared thirty-five weeks pregnant was torture in itself.

Beside me, Cheongpung stared at the City Lord's bulging belly with keen interest and whispered, "Benefactor. Do you think it's a boy or a girl?"

"Men can't give birth."

"Gasp!"

Still, he had come a long way. Just a year ago, he had firmly believed in the theory that cranes delivered babies by rocket express.

I addressed the City Lord, who had covered his lower body with the blanket and was watching me nervously.

"Neither of us gains anything by dragging this out, so I'll get straight to the point. We came to ask you for a favor."

"T-The messenger of His Highness Prince Shangshan need only speak. I will help to the fullest extent of my power."

"I'm looking for someone. First, how many people can you mobilize?"

The City Lord hesitated before answering uncertainly, "W-Well, I'm not sure. Excluding the forces needed to defend against invasions by the border tribes, I believe I could mobilize several thousand."

Several thousand government troops alone. If we added the constables from the local offices, the number would be even higher.

That was excellent news.

I smiled broadly, grabbed the City Lord by the shoulder, and pulled him to his feet.

"Then let's start by searching everywhere around Chengdu. The first condition is that the person must be a physician."

"A physician? The person you're looking for is a physician?"

"Yes. People call him the Divine Physician."

"Gasp! The Divine Physician? You mean *that* Divine Physician?"

"Why? Are you losing your nerve? If you do a good job, I could put in a good word for you with His Highness Prince Shangshan."

After thinking for a moment, the City Lord of Sichuan cried out in a trembling voice, "I will devote myself to completing the mission!"

Wobble, wobble.

"…"

No, everything else was fine, but he really needed to stop that from shaking too.

The reputation I had heard about the City Lord of Sichuan was the worst imaginable.

He was known as an incompetent official who had claimed his current position through his family's influence. His hobby was gobbling up bribes wherever he could get them, and his specialty was wine, women, and gambling—or so everyone said.

But he's the City Lord.

That was what mattered most. Just as I had borrowed the authority of Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao, the City Lord possessed the authority and power of the most powerful man in Sichuan.

"The City Lord of Sichuan, Won Gyun,[1721] commands this! Let every official in Sichuan carry out my orders without fail!"

Hearing his name had made me trust him considerably less, but a City Lord was still a City Lord.

Courier horses bearing official documents raced to every corner of Sichuan, and notices seeking the Divine Physician were posted throughout the marketplaces. Naturally, an enormous reward was offered to anyone who provided information.

"A thousand silver nyang! As expected of an acquaintance of His Highness Prince Shangshan, you are truly generous!"

Won Gyun's admiring gaze did not last long.

"What are you talking about? You're paying for all of it."

"…What?"

"Do I look like someone who carries around a thousand silver nyang?"

"N-No, but even so, that's an enormous sum."

"Then put it on credit. I'll mention it to His Highness Prince Shangshan later and ask him to reimburse you."

"No! I'll pay it myself!"

"By squeezing the lifeblood out of the common people? Or by squeezing the fat out of your own belly?"

"Even if I have to spend my personal fortune, I will pay it myself!"

"Wow. Our City Lord is so cool!"

An enormous reward capable of changing a person's life several times over, along with a huge number of people mobilized for the search.

But even that was not enough.

If the Divine Physician could be found with this much, the imperial court wouldn't have given up.

Who was the Divine Physician?

He was an unknown figure whom the imperial court had failed to find even after spreading a proclamation throughout the world in the emperor's name.

People like that generally preferred to avoid notice.

[1721] Won Gyun shares his name with a Korean admiral infamous for disastrous incompetence.

“Let the government troops handle the marketplaces and busy districts. We’ll search every scenic mountain and stream.”

“I agree.”

“I should’ve just stayed at Qingcheng…”

The hundreds of Disciples who had descended the mountain with the two Elders of the Qingcheng Sect were perfect for the task.

Three days after the government and Murim joined hands and began an unprecedented full-scale search, they finally arrived.

“Captain…”

The moment I saw the exhaustion written across Hyuk Mujin’s face and Gung Gibang standing beside him in grim silence, I understood.

Something went wrong.

I could not rejoice even though the men I had been waiting for had finally arrived. One look was enough to tell me they had not brought the news we had hoped for.

I walked forward without a word. Passing Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang, I stopped before the person behind them.

“I’m Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

She was a middle-aged nun. Her closely shaven head and pallid complexion immediately caught my eye.

She was the Emei Sect’s only reinforcement.

No. She looked more like the survivor of a routed army.

“Th-This humble nun’s Dharma name[1722] is Myoryeong… Cough.”

Drops of blood trickled down her chin.

An internal injury.

I caught her as she staggered. Looking into the eyes of Venerable Myoryeong, which seemed ready to fade away at any moment, I asked forcefully, “What on earth… happened?”

[1722] A Dharma name is a religious name taken by a Buddhist monastic.

Chapter 340

The middle-aged nun, Venerable Myoryeong, struggled to speak, her face pallid.

“The Venerable Nun… has entered nirvana.”

The moment I heard those words, my fist clenched on its own, and something deep in my chest sank with a heavy thud.

The two Elders of the Qingcheng Sect, who had rushed over after sensing the ominous mood, stared wide-eyed and shouted.

“Venerable Myoryeong, what do you mean? The Venerable Nun has entered nirvana?”

“That’s impossible! It can’t be!”

I already knew whom they meant by the Venerable Nun.

She, too, was one of the masters of the previous generation who remained vividly etched in Jeok Cheongang’s memories.

She was remarkably forthright. She stopped at nothing against her enemies, and her martial arts were outstanding. There were even times when she surpassed Hong Dao, that lazy bald monk.

During the Great Faction War, the Demonic Cult had feared her as the Blood Rakshasa[1723], while the Murim of the Central Plains had bestowed upon her the sobriquet Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun.

Even as the years passed and the heroes of the past vanished one by one, she remained on Mount Emei and held her ground.

She was the Emei Sect’s sole Supreme Peak master and its respected Sect Leader.

And now the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun was dead.

First the Poison King, and now the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun.

What a damned mess.

I finally spoke the words that had been hovering on the tip of my tongue.

“Who killed her?”

“…!”

“…!”

Venerable Myoryeong, Gung Gibang, Hyuk Mujin, and the two Elders of the Qingcheng Sect.

Five pairs of eyes turned toward me at once. All five held surprise, though not for the same reason.

“The culprit?”

“D-Do you mean someone murdered the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun…?”

[1723] A rakshasa is a malevolent being in Hindu and Buddhist traditions.

The two Elders of the Qingcheng Sect could not continue and fell silent. They had only belatedly realized what they had failed to notice in their shock at the news: Venerable Myoryeong's current condition.

Venerable Myoryeong's clothes were caked with dried, dark-red blood, and her complexion had turned a deathly blue.

She stared at me with wide eyes, then lowered her head.

"As expected, Young Hero Jin already knew."

As expected?

At my questioning look, Gung Gibang nodded gravely.

"We had no choice. The man who murdered the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun…"

"He's the same person as the culprit behind what happened at the Sichuan Tang Clan, or at least connected to him. I think so too."

The Elders, realizing there was something they did not know, asked in urgent voices,

"You knew about the killer? Has something happened to the Sichuan Tang Clan as well?"

"Tell us everything. Quickly!"

There was no hiding it now.

Perhaps this had been inevitable from the moment the Poison King was murdered.

I drew a deep breath and spoke.

"A few days ago, Great Hero Tang Taesang, the Poison King, passed away. More precisely, someone murdered him."

"…!"

"The Family Head, Great Hero Tang Sadok—the Myriad-Poison Asura—declared that he would have his revenge. By now, he should be pursuing the culprit with the members of his household."

But the Poison King had not been the only victim.

Leaving the stunned Elders behind me, I looked straight at Venerable Myoryeong.

"What happened?"

"It was a middle-aged man. He was missing one arm."

"A one-armed man?"

"Yes. He was…"

A trembling voice escaped Venerable Myoryeong's lips.

"He was a fiend incarnate."

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Fierce wind tore past us, and the surrounding scenery blurred with every stride.

The nun in my arms was astonishingly light, and the qi I could feel through our bodies was perilously faint.

She made it all the way here in this condition…

Venerable Myoryeong had not even finished telling us what had happened before vomiting a basinful of blood and losing consciousness.

Following close behind me, Gung Gibang spoke with a grim expression.

“How bad are her injuries?”

“Serious. I poured internal energy into her to bolster her vitality for now, but… it won’t be enough.”

Gung Gibang let out a quiet groan.

“She wasn’t this bad when we first set out. Venerable Myoryeong insisted she could endure the journey.”

“You should’ve stopped her anyway, you bastard.”

“…There was no stopping her. I’m sorry.”

My lips moved, but I pressed them shut without speaking.

I knew. Even if I had gone instead of Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin, I could not have stopped Venerable Myoryeong.

Even as she vomited blood, the voice she had forced out still rang vividly in my ears.

“The Sect Leader and all three Elders… That fiend killed them all. I—we couldn’t chase him as he walked away smiling.”

She said the fiend had descended upon Mount Emei, the sacred mountain of Buddhism, only three days ago.

The demon had climbed the mountain like any other pilgrim and sought out the residence where the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun lived. Three Elders happened to be there at the time.

Then a battle that shook heaven and earth erupted. A mountain peak collapsed, and Mount Emei itself trembled.

What Venerable Myoryeong had witnessed after recognizing the disaster and rushing there from the nearest location was four dead nuns and a single demon.

“Don’t look at me like that. My art of killing was simply stronger than Emei’s Dharma[1724].”

“H-How could you do such a thing? Do you truly not fear Heaven?”

“How laughable. The Buddha and Heaven you speak of are all lies and illusions. I will show you that I have another Heaven.”

That was the last thing he said.

[1724] Dharma refers here to Buddhist teachings.

The killer struck Venerable Myoryeong with a palm and disappeared. Then, while the Emei Sect was consumed by grief and rage, two young men arrived.

After Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin told her that members of the Qingcheng Sect were nearby, she ignored everyone's attempts to stop her and descended Mount Emei.

"Please help us. Please! No matter what, we must stop that fiend… Cough!"

Remembering Venerable Myoryeong crying out until the moment she lost consciousness made me clench my teeth.

Just what kind of bastard was he…?

A one-armed, middle-aged man. A master with enough terrifying martial prowess to single-handedly kill the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun, a Supreme Peak master of the previous generation, along with three Elders.

What was his purpose? Why had he done such a thing? And was he the same man who had murdered Tang Taesang, the Poison King?

What if he wasn't?

The moment my thoughts reached that point, a chill ran down my spine, and my heart began pounding violently.

If the two incidents had been committed by different people… it was only a matter of time before Sichuan became a land of death.

Just as my previously effortless steps began to grow heavy, the two Elders of the Qingcheng Sect spoke.

"I think we should part ways here."

"I'm sorry, but circumstances leave us no other choice."

It was only natural for them to worry about their own sect.

First the Sichuan Tang Clan, and now the Emei Sect. Anyone with a brain could guess that the Qingcheng Sect might be next.

"There's no need to apologize. I would have done the same."

"Thank you for understanding."

"Are you going straight to Mount Qingcheng?"

The older of the two Elders shook his head.

"I will lead some of our Disciples to assist the Emei Sect. My Junior Brother will return to the main sect with the remaining Disciples. What about you?"

"Venerable Myoryeong's injuries are worse than I thought. I intend to find a physician first, then contact the Sichuan Tang Clan."

With so many of their members away, the Sichuan Tang Clan and the Qingcheng Sect had both been left virtually undefended. They needed to be warned, just in case.

The Elder, whose own sect was in the same position, understood that perfectly well.

“For now, focus on treating Venerable Myoryeong. We will send someone to the Sichuan Tang Clan.”

“Thank you.”

“Think nothing of it. May fortune favor your martial path.”

“And yours.”

We exchanged martial salutes and split into three groups.

The two Elders led their respective groups of Disciples north and east, leaving only four people, including me.

Ah. Jeok Cheongang and Venerable Myoryeong were here too.

We had come all the way to Sichuan to heal one patient, but instead of finding the Divine Physician, we had gained another.

What is this, some kind of hidden-camera prank?

Fuck, as if.

I heaved an inward sigh and was about to start walking again when—

Step. Step.

Light footsteps came up the dirt path, accompanied by cheerful humming. A boy climbing the mountain trail finally spotted us and opened his eyes wide.

“Huh? Wha—?”

It was a familiar face. The boy’s name was Mungyeong.

I was glad to see him again after only a few days, but before that feeling could fully surface, another thought flashed through my mind.

“Mungyeong.”

“What brings everyone here…? Huh?”

“You’re a medical apprentice, right?”

I still remembered him treating people on the deck of the swift ship.

I did not know exactly what treatment he had provided, but according to the river bandits, he was quite skilled.

“Yeees. I am, but…”

Mungyeong answered with a bewildered expression, then looked at Venerable Myoryeong in my arms. No further explanation was necessary.

He pulled a wooden case of acupuncture and moxibustion[1725] tools from the travel bag in his arms and strode toward us.

“First… let me examine the patient.”

Swish.

It took Mungyeong only moments to check her pulse and insert the needles.

[1725] Moxibustion is a traditional treatment that applies heat by burning dried mugwort near the body.

Yet despite handling the entire process with effortless fluidity, a shadow hung over his face.

"…How is she?"

I did not need to ask to know the answer would not be good.

Sure enough, Mungyeong quietly shook his head.

"Not good. Not at all."

"You managed to give her some basic treatment, right?"

"Yes."

I let out a sigh of relief.

It might have been unkind, but I had never expected much from Mungyeong in the first place. He was young and had only been studying medicine for a short time.

Basic treatment was all I had wanted from him.

"You did well. That's enough for now. If we get to Chengdu as quickly as possible and find a way…"

"Will that really be enough?"

"What?"

"In one month, her flesh will begin to rot. In four months, her bones will melt away."

"Hold on. What the hell are you talking about…?"

But Mungyeong continued in the same quiet voice.

"After half a year of horrific pain, she will look like a living corpse. She might survive a year at most. Once her organs begin to rot, she will finally stop breathing."

"…What?"

"Even if you take her to Chengdu, you won't find any suitable treatment. The physicians available among the common people can only handle women's ailments of the sort suffered by high officials and nobles. And the Sichuan Tang Clan…"

Two things shocked me.

First, that Venerable Myoryeong's injuries were so severe.

Second, the unfamiliar sight of Mungyeong calmly describing something so horrifying.

"I heard rumors all over the marketplace that the Tang Clan's martial artists had headed west. It will take them several days at least to return. By then, it will be too late. How long ago was she injured?"

Hyuk Mujin answered haltingly.

"Th-Three days. A little over three days, I think."

"Three days…"

Mungyeong let out a quiet groan, then continued in a heavy voice.

“The Black Hand Seal is a terrifying evil technique. Once seven days and nights have passed, there will be no turning back.”

Grab!

That was as far as he got.

My patience snapped. Unable to hold back any longer, I seized him by the collar.

“You… How the hell do you know that?”

A teenage medical apprentice had just named an evil technique no one else present had ever heard of.

The Mungyeong I knew could never have possessed such knowledge.

“Tell me. Now.”

Mungyeong swallowed hard at my chilling aura before answering,

“My Master… My Master told me everything.”

“Your Master?”

“Y-Yes. Yes… Cough!”

A flash of realization streaked through my mind.

The strength drained from the hand gripping his collar.

A murmur like a groan slipped from my lips.

“The Divine Physician…?”

Chapter 341

A conversation I'd had with Mungyeong several days ago flashed through my mind.

Thank you for everything.

Forget the thanks. Just focus on becoming a great physician.

Like the Divine Physician?

Yes, like the Divine Physician.

And then there was the last thing he had said almost in passing.

It's a shame we can't go together this time. I have to return to my Master.

How had I not realized it?

Looking back, Mungyeong had been unusual from the very beginning. He had shown incredible resourcefulness when the river bandits threatened his life, composure far beyond his years, and remarkable medical skill.

That's not all.

The boy had nearly sunk to the bottom of the Yangtze because of the river bandits, yet he had brazenly hitched a ride aboard the swift ship and then visited the Sichuan Tang Clan—infamous throughout Murim for their vicious tempers—just to get a prescription.

Mungyeong had casually done things that even martial artists with Botox injected into their livers might have shied away from.

And on top of that, the things he just said and did…

I had no idea what kind of martial art the Black Hand Seal was or how powerful it might be.

But I knew one thing for certain.

"The Divine Physician. You're the Divine Physician's Disciple."

"…!"

"…!"

The others stared wide-eyed at Mungyeong after hearing the joy and deflation mingled in my words.

A suffocating silence descended over us, and Mungyeong shrank back.

"I-I'm sorry. But I couldn't tell you."

"Why not?"

I regretted asking the moment the words left my mouth. The Divine Physician had spent his entire life hiding his identity. Of course his Disciple had kept silent.

If Venerable Myoryeong's life had not been hanging by a thread, Mungyeong almost certainly would never have revealed his Master's identity.

"Where is the Divine Physician—or rather, where is your Master?"

Mungyeong hesitated, then bit his lip tightly.

“But before that, could you promise me one thing?”

“I’ll keep the secret. Absolutely.”

With that firm answer, I pulled something from inside my robe and held it out.

Lately, I had been taking it out of my Inventory and examining it whenever I had a spare moment.

> The finest Chinese gallnuts come from Sichuan.

Mungyeong’s eyes widened when he saw the faint writing on the jade-colored porcelain shard.

“This is…”

“Do you recognize it?”

“Yes. It’s unmistakably my Master’s handwriting.”

Mungyeong examined the Divine Physician’s Token from every angle, apparently fascinated, then let out a small exclamation.

“Come to think of it, my Master once told me that a very long time ago, he left a token with a famous physician and told him to come to Sichuan. But how did you come to possess it, Young Master…?”

“The famous physician gave it to me directly. There’s a patient whom no one but the Divine Physician can treat.”

I continued emphatically.

“There’s someone I have to save.”

“I don’t know who that person is, but… you hold them very dear, Young Master.”

Someone dear to me.

Yes. I supposed that was true. Jeok Cheongang was precious to me. He had given me everything he had, and now it was my turn to protect him.

“Yes. That’s right.”

Mungyeong smiled faintly and nodded.

“Come with me. I’ll take you to my Master.”

Crunch. Crunch.

The snow crunched beneath our feet with every step.

I looked around. Bare branches covered in frost. Thick white snow blanketing everything in sight.

It doesn’t get any less incredible.

Outside, it was early spring, and new shoots were beginning to emerge. But the place we were walking through looked like the depths of winter after a heavy snowfall.

So this is a Mystic Gate Formation…

Mungyeong had led us to the very same mountain we had searched with the Qingcheng Sect. But when we reached a certain point, he strained to move several rocks, and an entirely new path and landscape unfolded before us.

It was unlike anything we had ever seen. Every last one of us had stood there with our mouths hanging open.

Mungyeong told us that the formation had been installed by the Master of Strange Illusions.

According to Gung Gibang, who had sprayed spit everywhere as he explained, the Master of Strange Illusions had been known as the greatest formation master under heaven in the distant past.

I had no idea what sort of connection he had shared with the Divine Physician, but he had installed something like this. We had nearly wandered around for ages despite being right on top of the place.

No wonder nobody could find him.

What good was it to deploy top-tier Murim artists and countless government troops?

If they had searched each mountain one by one using ordinary methods, even half a century would not have been enough, let alone six months.

“Wow! Woooow!”

Cheongpung, who had been running several steps ahead of us like a puppy let loose in a snowy field, cried out in delight. I was about to scold him when the scenery changed completely the very next moment, and my mouth fell open too.

“…Whoa. What the hell is this?”

The world had changed again in the space of a few steps.

The snow-white depths of winter had given way to spring in full bloom.

Everything around us was green, and nameless flowers were in full bloom. Hyuk Mujin approached with a dazed expression and asked,

“Captain. Am I seeing things?”

“I don’t know, Mujin.”

Even Gung Gibang, the most experienced in Murim among us, stood there with his mouth hanging open.

“Good heavens… Hk! Ptooey, ptooey! What is this?”

“Butterflies?”

Oh, they really were butterflies. And not just one or two.

Every color imaginable.

Hundreds of butterflies resting throughout the flower field took flight at once. It was a spectacular sight.

Whoooosh.

Where had the wind suddenly come from? And where was the bright sunlight pouring in from?

Every single thing I saw felt like one of the Seven Wonders of the World.

The pyramids have nothing on this.

There was a place where the seasons changed after only a few steps, so what were the pyramids compared to that? Some Egyptian logistics officer probably just ran his workers ragged building them.

All the pharaoh had to do was put on a solemn face and say, “This pharaoh is disappointed in you,” a few times, and they would be hauling stones while getting whipped.

But this place…

This was on an entirely different level.

“Young Master Jin?”

“Huh? Oh, yeah.”

“We’re almost there. We only have to cross that hill.”

We hurriedly came to our senses and followed Mungyeong again.

Once we crossed the low hill covered in green grass, a small thatched hut came into view, standing alone on a flat stretch of land.

And…

He was there.

“Master!”

At Mungyeong’s shout, an old man planting something in the vegetable garden before the hut straightened his bent back. His beard was as white as the snow we had seen along the way. His eyes were clear and framed by deep wrinkles.

When he noticed us, the corners of his eyes curved gently.

“Some honored guests have arrived.”

We had finally found him.

The Divine Physician.

It was a long while before we properly spoke with the Divine Physician.

After examining Venerable Myoryeong, the Divine Physician had Mungyeong carry her into the hut. The two of them did not emerge again until a shichen[1726] later.

[1726] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

“It has been a long time since anyone came to visit.”

The Divine Physician’s sudden voice was like a cool spring breeze. I had been pacing around the hut and hurriedly bowed.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan pays his respects to the Divine Physician.”

“Dong Feng.”

“Pardon?”

“That is my name. The title Divine Physician is too grand for me, so please call me Old Man Dong.”

How could I call the greatest physician under heaven Old Man Dong, as if he were some old man Kim at a neighborhood real estate office?

I was young enough to be his grandson, too.

But when I met the Divine Physician’s benevolent gaze, I had no choice but to quietly comply.

“Yes. I will, Old Man Dong.”

“Thank you, Young Master Jin.”

The Divine Physician smiled gently, then exchanged greetings with everyone else, one by one.

He remained courteous even toward those of us who were far younger than him, and he never once seemed hurried.

“Hello! I’m Cheongpung!”

He did not even lose his smile in front of the local lunatic.

“Heh heh. You’re a very energetic person. My name is Dong Feng. You may call me Old Man Dong, just like the others.”

“But my grandfather told me I have to show respect to my elders.”

“Your grandfather gave you an excellent lesson. But if our hearts are at ease with each other, what harm is there? Just think of me as a friend who happens to be a little older than you.”

“A friend?”

“That’s right. A friend.”

Cheongpung smiled brightly.

“Then let’s get along, Old Man Dong!”

“Heh heh. Heh heh heh!”

He’s laughing?

Was he some kind of Murim Joker? The type who laughed when he was angry and laughed when he was dumbfounded?

“Old Man Dong, have you ever tried candy?”

“I like sweets. I used to enjoy candied hawthorn skewers,[1727] too.”

“Hey, me too!”

The setting looked like a healing movie, but the conversation was pure horror thriller. In the end, Gung Gibang’s face went deathly pale. He clamped both hands over Cheongpung’s mouth and slowly backed away.

The Divine Physician laughed heartily at the sight, then turned to Mungyeong.

“You have brought some interesting people.”

Mungyeong bowed deeply.

“I’m sorry, Master. I brought them without your permission.”

“No, no. Heaven brings people together through fate. This, too, must be the natural order. Wouldn’t you agree?”

His last question was directed at me. I nodded and held out the Divine Physician’s Token I had prepared in advance.

“This is…”

“This is a token you left behind long ago, Divine Physician—or rather, Old Man Dong. The Luoyang Strange Physician gave it to me and told me to seek you out.”

“I did?”

“Pardon?”

No way. Had he forgotten about it?

The Divine Physician tilted his head. Only after Mungyeong reminded him again did he let out a small exclamation.

“Ah, yes. I remember now. It happened so long ago that it had slipped my mind.”

“Whew. For a moment, I thought you’d forgotten completely.”

“In any case, if you possess this token… that must mean something has happened that requires this old man’s aid.”

“Yes, that’s right.”

“Is it about the nun you brought here? If so, there is no need to worry too much. She has already made it past the immediate crisis.”

The Divine Physician looked toward the hut where Venerable Myoryeong lay and continued.

“It will not be an easy road, but… once the rest of her treatment is complete, sufficient rest should allow her to make a full recovery.”

It was the best news I had heard in a long time. Not only had Venerable Myoryeong escaped the brink of death, but the Divine Physician truly possessed medical skill worthy of his reputation.

I took a deep breath before speaking.

“There’s another patient.”

[1727] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating fruit in hardened sugar.

“Another patient?”

“The person who gave me the token said that there was only one person under heaven who could treat him. You.”

“Only I can treat him…”

The Divine Physician repeated the words quietly, then spoke.

“Birth, aging, sickness, and death are not things a mere human can decide. But if there is even the slightest possibility, I will do my best as a physician.”

“That’s enough… That’s all I need.”

There had been a time when my mother was sick.

The doctor in charge of her surgery had said the same thing.

I’ll do my best.

For Hayeon and me, those words had been our only hope, and the surgery had been a success.

Just as I had done with that doctor in the past, I tightly gripped the Divine Physician’s wrinkled hand.

“Please. Old Man Dong.”

The Divine Physician smiled benevolently, as though he understood everything.

“Let us see the patient first.”

After that came nothing but waiting and anxiety.

Once Jeok Cheongang, who had been lying on the pack frame, was carried into the hut, I paced back and forth, waiting for the Divine Physician and Mungyeong to emerge.

Butterflies and honeybees flitted through the flower field, and fresh green leaves sprouted from the trees, but I felt nothing.

It went well, right? It must have gone well.

I could not even bring myself to approach the hut, afraid that I might hear something negative.

I walked for a long time, endlessly repeating that single thought.

Only after the sunlight had faded and a pale darkness settled over the land did I return to the hut.

There, the exhausted Divine Physician and Mungyeong were waiting for me with faint smiles.

“I believe I can treat him.”

The instant I heard those words, all the strength drained from my legs, and a familiar alert pierced my ears.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest condition, **Get Examined by the Divine Physician**, completed!

Quest, **Find Mr. Shin in Sichuan**, successfully completed!

Chapter 342

Finding Mr. Shin in Sichuan had been a Supreme Peak Grade Quest. With difficulty that vicious, the rewards were bound to be substantial.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

A massive EXP payout and the resulting Level Up. Even an achievement.

I dismissed the incessant System notifications and the holographic windows blocking my view. I couldn't simply celebrate when the Divine Physician looked so grim.

"What's wrong? You haven't changed your mind, have you? You're not about to tell me you can't treat him after all, right?"

"Of course not. I may be an old quack, but if I give it my all, there is still plenty of hope."

"Then why do you look like that…?"

He hesitated before letting out a soft sigh. The faint smile on his lips had vanished, replaced by deeply troubled lines.

"There are too many things we must prepare for the treatment."

"Oh, if this is about the cost, you don't need to worry."

I might not look it, but I was the youngest son of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. It was common knowledge that the Jin Family had amassed a fortune through the northern trade routes over the past few years.

"If things get desperate, I can always borrow some money from this guy's family. Hey, there are Hyuk Family textile shops in Sichuan too, aren't there?"

Hyuk Mujin nodded, looking less than thrilled.

"There are. We're textile merchants. It would be strange if we didn't have a shop in Sichuan, considering how famous it is for silk."

"Then let's borrow some emergency cash. We can sell the shop if we have to, right?"

"Of course not."

"I'll pay you plenty of interest."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then I'll give you plenty of travel money for your journey to the next world."

"…Just take it all. Go ahead and rip out the very foundations of my family while you're at it."

Okay, problem solved.

But for some reason, the Divine Physician's expression remained dark.

His Master seemed unable to bring himself to speak, so Mungyeong stepped in.

"Um, Young Master Jin."

"Yes?"

"That isn't the biggest problem. The treatment will require an enormous amount of money, but some materials would be difficult to obtain no matter how much gold and silver we had."

"Materials that are difficult to obtain…? Are you talking about an elixir?"

"Yes. Treating Great Hero Jeok requires an elixir that meets certain conditions. Such elixirs are extremely valuable and rare. If we begin searching now, we may have to wait several years before finding one."

Several years?

That was far too long. Jeok Cheongang had only a few months left to live.

I was struck speechless. The Divine Physician continued in a somber voice.

"I believe a detailed explanation is in order. The patient has not regained consciousness because the balance within his body has been disrupted."

"His balance?"

"All things in the world contain the energies of the Five Elements and exist in proper balance. The human body is no different. But the patient attempted to wield an enormous force and destroyed that balance."

An enormous force?

The Divine Physician's words brought something to mind.

Dance of the Fire God and Demon. The Fire Gate Clan's ultimate secret technique, which drew out and amplified every ounce of power its user possessed.

So that was the cause.

In the distant past, Jeok Cheongang had earned the name Fire King by using the Dance of the Fire God and Demon against a thousand members of the Demonic Cult. But as the years passed, his old and diseased body could no longer endure that power. It had shattered.

"When a vessel breaks, whatever it held inside will inevitably leak out. Fortunately, there is a way to reverse the damage, but it requires an elixir rarely seen in this world."

"An elixir rarely seen in this world…"

"And even among such elixirs, it must meet certain conditions."

"Tell me. I'll get it, no matter what it takes."

The Divine Physician sighed and nodded.

"It will be extremely difficult, but what choice do we have? We must place our hopes in you, Young Master. Listen carefully to what I am about to say."

"Yes."

In a grave voice, the Divine Physician explained Jeok Cheongang's condition, the method of treatment, and the requirements for the necessary elixir.

"Will you remember all of that?"

"…"

"Young Master?"

"Oh, yes."

"I asked whether you remember all of it."

"Yes. I remember everything. But this is… Whew."

"…"

"Could you check—I mean, confirm that I heard everything correctly?"

"I was planning to do so anyway. Go ahead."

I carefully began to speak.

"So, the excessive expenditure of power disrupted his balance, and the harmony between Yin and Yang was particularly badly damaged?"

"That is correct."

"And the cause was an enormous amount of Scorching Yang Qi that had gone out of control."

"Continue."

"To restore that broken balance and bring everything back into harmony, we need an elixir—and an incredibly powerful one at that. And for that…"

Mungyeong quickly cut in.

"Among elixirs, it must possess the nature of Yin-Cold Qi. It must also contain at least one jiazi's[1728] worth of energy."

"Four months," the Divine Physician said heavily. "If we cannot find one within four months, everything else will be pointless."

At that moment, the conversation came to an end.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A Chain Quest, Thirty Thousand Li[1729] in Search of an Elixir, has been generated.

This is something you must accomplish. You cannot refuse!

Find an elixir containing at least one jiazi[1730] of energy and possessing the nature of Yin-Cold Qi!

I stared blankly at the holographic window before finally coming to my senses.

[1728] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Here it measures an equivalent amount of accumulated energy.

[1729] The quest title uses the Korean *ri*, a traditional distance unit. One ri is about 393 m (0.244 mi); thirty thousand ri would be about 11,790 km (7,320 mi).

[1730] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Here it measures an equivalent amount of accumulated energy.

"Will that do?"

"Many other materials are necessary, but this will be the most important one—the core ingredient. You must depart immediately and search for the elixir…"

"Ah, yes."

And so I departed.

I took two steps toward the Divine Physician, pulled something from inside my robe, and held it out.

"Here."

"…?"

"…?"

"Take it."

Master and Disciple stared blankly at me, then simultaneously reached out to accept the object.

"What is this?"

"Master, perhaps you should open it first."

"W-Well, shall I?"

Click.

The Divine Physician swallowed nervously and carefully opened the wooden box. A pure, clear fragrance that seemed capable of purifying even the coronavirus wafted out as *it* revealed itself.

"Gasp!"

"Good heavens!"

"It's a Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng. It contains at least one jiazi's[1731] worth of energy and possesses the nature of Yin-Cold Qi. Is this enough?"

Eyes wide, the Divine Physician looked back and forth between me and the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, then nodded vigorously.

"It is enough!"

Ding.

[1731] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Here it measures an equivalent amount of accumulated energy.

[1732] The quest title uses the Korean *ri*, a traditional distance unit. One ri is about 393 m (0.244 mi); thirty thousand ri would be about 11,790 km (7,320 mi).

SYSTEM

Quest conditions fulfilled!
Chain Quest, Thirty Thousand Li[1732] in Search of an Elixir, successfully completed!
Achievement, Mountain Herb Gatherer, acquired!
A substantial amount of EXP acquired!
Level Up!

As the System notifications rang out, Ju Hwaran suddenly came to mind.

Thank you, Young Lady Ju.

I let out a wry chuckle as I thought of how she had given it to me while passing the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng off as Hundred-Year-Old Snow Ginseng, worried I might feel burdened and refuse it otherwise.

Now I have a reason to stop by Shaanxi on the way back.

And when I did… I hoped Jeok Cheongang would be healthy again and traveling with me.

I turned to the Divine Physician, who still looked dazed.

"All right, then. What do we do next?"

The Divine Physician carefully tucked the wooden box into his robes and began walking.

"Follow me. Gyeong, remain here and look after the patients."

"Yes, Master."

Leaving Mungyeong behind as he answered respectfully, we followed the Divine Physician.

Swish!

A small figure sped along right beside me. Every time he extended one foot, a zhang[1733] of distance vanished and the wind swept past.

What was truly astonishing was that his feet never touched the ground.

With each faint tap of his toes, the blades of grass bent gently beneath him, then sprang back into place.

I narrowed my eyes.

Flying Over Grass?

Flying Over Grass was a realm in which one ran as though flying while stepping across blades of grass.

[1733] A *zhang* is a traditional length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Martial artists who had mastered their movement techniques to the Peak realm could perform such feats. Treading Snow Without a Trace, which left no footprints even while running across snow, and Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water, which allowed one to walk across water as though it were solid ground, worked on similar principles.

Stepping on Empty Air, meanwhile, was a realm attainable only by Supreme Peak masters with internal energy to spare.

Of course, Flying Over Grass isn't beyond me either if I put my mind to it.

Even so, the sight was astonishing because the person performing it was the Divine Physician.

I knew he had learned martial arts, but his movement technique is especially impressive.

I had realized the Divine Physician knew martial arts the moment we first met.

Though small in stature, he possessed vitality and resilience comparable to a young martial artist's. The energy stored in his dantian was considerable as well.

His martial arts are First Rate, and his internal energy is probably around Peak.

As I quietly assessed him, the Divine Physician sensed my gaze. He turned his head and smiled.

"What is it?"

I answered honestly.

"Your movement technique is remarkable."

"Heh heh. No matter how hard this old man tries, how could I compare with you, Young Master? I merely happened to learn it."

"Honestly, before meeting the Divine Physician—or rather, Old Man Dong—I never imagined you had learned martial arts."

"You must have been surprised. The others seem to feel the same."

I glanced behind me. Everyone except Cheongpung looked ready to burst with curiosity.

There was no point being vague now. Better to ask him outright.

"This may be presumptuous, but may I ask how you came to learn martial arts?"

A physician practicing martial arts. It might have been an uncomfortable subject, but the Divine Physician did not avoid the question.

"When I was around twenty, shortly after becoming a medical apprentice, my Master personally instructed me."

"Then was your Master perhaps…?"

"That is correct. My Master was a martial artist."

The Divine Physician's Master had been a martial artist. That was something I had never expected.

Seeing my expression, he let out a hearty laugh.

“Heh heh. There is no need to be surprised. By the time he accepted me as his Disciple, he had already left the Murim.”

“Oh, I see.”

“My Master had reached the highest realm both as a martial artist and as a physician. He told me he had become a physician to atone for all the lives he had taken.”

For some reason, I felt as though I understood.

I had accumulated killing karma too. At first, I swung my spear while thinking only of getting home and believing that this was merely a fictional world created by a game.

But everything was real. They were all living people.

By the time I realized that, it was already too late.

I could not stop, and I did not stop. I killed to survive. I killed because they were my enemies.

In the Murim and in the modern world.

At some point, the scent of blood had seeped deep into my body. It was a stench that no amount of washing could remove.

“…I see.”

At my belated reply, the Divine Physician gave me a gentle smile.

“It was simply a matter of choice. My Master chose the path he believed was right, and I did the same. However, so many people came looking for this old man that I had no choice but to learn martial arts for my own protection. I was born a dullard, so he scolded me quite often. Heh heh.”

Everyone has memories.

Perhaps remembering the days he had spent with his Master, the Divine Physician suddenly stopped walking in the middle of his laughter.

“Well, we have arrived.”

Crack.

A frozen leaf crumbled beneath someone’s foot.

We stood in an unusually cold valley within the Mystic Gate Formation surrounding the Divine Physician’s residence.

“Where exactly are we?”

“I call this place the Cold-Ice Land.”

Cold-Ice Land. A fitting name.

Though something like Yanggu in Gangwon Province or Moscow might have been even better.

I glanced at Hyuk Mujin, who had already begun shivering violently, then asked the most important question.

“What do we do now?”

“You will have quite a difficult time. We must find and dig up various ingredients, including the medicinal herbs needed for the initial stage of treatment.”

“That sounds simpler than I expected.”

“Let me see… A hundred roots of each should be enough.”

“Ah, yes. A hundred roots.”

“I said a hundred roots of *each*.”

“Yes. That’s what you said. A hundred roots.”

I nodded, then froze.

Wait. What had I just heard?

“A hundred roots *each*? Not a hundred in total?”

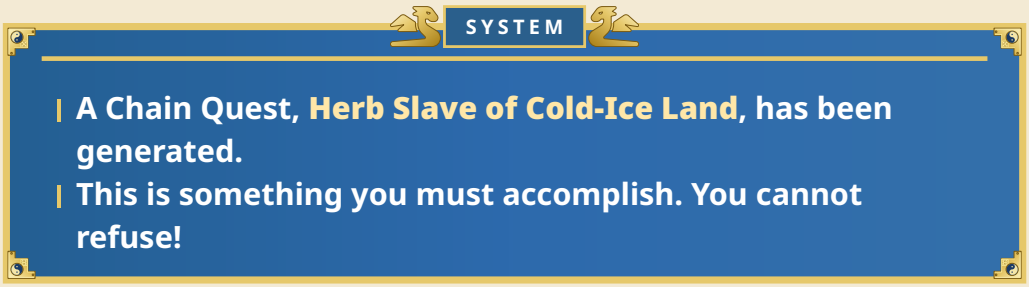
“That is correct.”

The Divine Physician continued with a hearty laugh.

“A hundred roots each of twenty-four different kinds.”

“…!”

Ding.



Chapter 343

Whoooooosh.

“This wind is fucking brutal. Goddamn it.”

I shuddered as the bitter cold pierced straight through my leather clothes. *Unaffected by Cold and Heat*, my ass. More like *Very Much Affected by Cold and Heat*.

“Pfooh-chew!”

I turned around, wondering what bizarre sound that had been, and found Hyuk Mujin rubbing his blue-tinged nose.

When our eyes met, his eyes curved into hooks.

“What? What is it?”

“…”

“What are you looking at?”

“No, I was just fascinated by the sound of your sneeze…”

“Seriously? You find the strangest things fascinating. If you have that much time to spare, dig up another herb.”

“…All right. My bad.”

I quietly looked away and scanned the area for another herb.

It had already been five days since I had taken a job as a herb slave in Cold-Ice Land. The hierarchy between us had reversed a long time ago.

“Ah, what are you doing? There’s one right over there. There!”

“Oh. So there is.”

“Get your head in the game!”

Ugh. It wasn’t like I could punch him.

If he had followed a friend to Gangnam, at least the land prices would have gone up. Instead, Hyuk Mujin had followed me to Cold-Ice Land and was suffering through the worst ordeal of his life.

He had been dragged into all kinds of fights before and always stopped after grumbling a few times, so the fact that he was now glaring at me with murder in his eyes said everything.

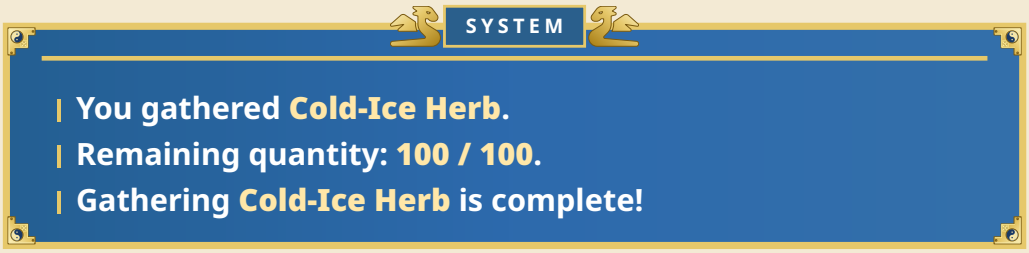
“I’ll dig for herbs beyond that hill. Don’t stop working. I’ll come back and check on you every so often.”

“…Got it, you punk.”

Repeating the character for patience to myself, I gently dug through the snow and pulled up an herb.

The moment I placed it in the basket our exploitative employer—or rather, the Divine Physician—had issued to each of his herb slaves, a System notification rang out.

Ding.



“Whew. Finally finished another one.”

At least the finish line was coming into sight.

As I checked the Quest window to see how much remained, Gung Gibang approached me, shivering violently.

“Hey, how many are left?”

“About two hundred roots. If things go well, we might finish today.”

“Two hundred roots are still left?”

“Only two hundred. Hang in there a little longer.”

“No. Two hundred roots is far too many. By then, I’ll be a frozen corpse buried somewhere under this snow.”

“…”

What a load of crap.

Still trembling, Gung Gibang pulled a fire striker from inside his clothes and lit it.

He brought his face close to the tiny flame and murmured wistfully, “I miss my Master. I miss the days when I begged in the alley outside a warm inn…”

Was he the Little Match Girl?[1734]

I muttered, dumbfounded by his behavior.

“You were still a beggar back then.”

“At least I was a warm beggar. That’s a hundred times better than being a cold one.”

“…You have a point.”

“I want to go back to those days. A lazy noon, sunlight pouring down. A delicious-looking yellow dog strolling past…”

What the hell was a *delicious-looking* yellow dog?

Gung Gibang’s eyelids slowly drooped after he said something that would make any animal-protection group scream.

This bastard couldn’t possibly be—

“Hey! Hey!”

I hurriedly sent Scorching Yang Qi into his body.

[1734] *The Little Match Girl* is a Hans Christian Andersen fairy tale about a girl who lights matches for warmth on a freezing night.

He had to come to his senses somehow—

“It’s warm…”

“I said wake up, you lunatic!”

Smack! Smack!

It was no use. No matter how hard I slapped his cheeks, his eyes showed no sign of opening again.

I continued sending Scorching Yang Qi into him and shouted, “Is anyone there? Somebody get over here, quick!”

In response to my desperate cry, someone came sprinting over from far away.

“Benefactor! Benefactor!”

“Nice, Cheongpung! Quick, take this guy outside—”

Cheongpung ran over like the wind, beaming as he held something out to me.

“Benefactor, look! It’s the first snowman I’ve ever made!”

“You son of a bitch!”

The Divine Physician inspected all the herbs in the baskets and nodded.

“This should be enough.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Chain Quest, Herb Slave of Cold-Ice Land, successfully completed!

Achievement, Mountain Herb Gatherer Who Returned Alive from Hell, acquired!

You acquired 10 bonus points for earning an achievement!

Just look at that achievement title.

I didn’t even have the strength to get angry anymore.

The Divine Physician looked over our utterly exhausted group before his gaze suddenly stopped on one person.

“Why is Young Master Cheongpung so dejected?”

Because I had smashed the first snowman Cheongpung had ever made with my Flame Divine Palm.

I glared murderously at the still-sullen Cheongpung and asked the Divine Physician, “So, are all the preparations complete now?”

“They are. With this quantity, we will be prepared for anything that may happen later.”

“Prepared?”

The Divine Physician nodded gravely.

“We do not know what may happen.”

I suddenly realized something I had forgotten.

The Divine Physician had never once been certain.

He had only seen a possibility and said that he would do his best.

It isn’t over until it’s over.

The words I whispered to myself whenever I faced a crisis now became a dagger stabbing into my chest.

In the end, there was only one thing I could say.

“Please… Please do your very best.”

“This old man will do everything within his power. I promise.”

Mungyeong, who stood beside the Divine Physician, spoke with conviction.

“I will also do everything I can to assist my Master.”

“Thank you.”

“There’s no need. It is only natural for a medical apprentice to do so.”

“Then when will the actual treatment begin?”

The Divine Physician considered the question for a moment before answering.

“Probably in seven days and nights. Until then, Mungyeong and I will combine and refine the twenty-four types of herbs you brought us, preparing them as ingredients for the Life-Restoring Great Technique.”

“All of them?”

“This is only a portion of what we need. Fortunately, I already possess the remaining ingredients required for the Life-Restoring Great Technique, which allowed us to shorten the preparation time.”

“What exactly is this Life-Restoring Great Technique…?”

The Divine Physician stroked his snow-white beard and answered.

“As I mentioned before, my Master was once a martial artist. He primarily practiced medicine among the common people, but he was also deeply versed in controlling qi.”

Hearing that, I had a rough idea where this was going.

Hyuk Mujin suddenly cut in with an exclamation.

“Martial artists! The Life-Restoring Great Technique was created to treat martial artists!”

“That is correct. The Master of Strange Illusions was one of them. After recovering from severe qi deviation thanks to the Life-Restoring Great Technique, he installed the Mystic Gate Formation for us before departing.”

For martial artists, qi deviation was practically a death sentence. Their internal energy reversed course, their qi and blood became tangled, and all their acupoints and dantian were damaged.

The easiest way to understand it was to imagine a small bomb exploding inside a person.

But he cured qi deviation.

If the Master of Strange Illusions had suffered qi deviation severe enough for the Divine Physician to describe it that way, he must have been little more than a walking corpse at the time.

Just hearing the story gave me some idea of how effective the Life-Restoring Great Technique was.

Then Old Master will definitely—

I quickly shook off the thought before it could finish forming.

There was no reason to be certain yet, nor any need to worry.

"Please take good care of him."

"Until preparations for the technique are complete, no one may approach the place where the patient is being kept. Do you understand?"

"Yes."

"By then, the Life-Restoring Great Technique will be ready, and we should have a clearer understanding of the patient's condition. Please wait patiently until then."

"I'll keep that in mind."

"Remember. Seven days and nights."

But the Divine Physician was unable to keep his word.

He reappeared with Mungyeong after only three days, and the moment I saw their expressions, I knew something had happened.

"…What is it?"

After a long silence, it was Mungyeong—not the Divine Physician—who finally spoke.

"Formless Ultimate Poison."

"What?"

"There is an unidentified, extremely deadly poison inside the patient's body. That was the true cause."

"W-Wait."

My thoughts twisted into a chaotic knot.

Formless Ultimate Poison? Out of nowhere?

I looked at the Divine Physician in confusion.

"What does that mean?"

"Exactly what you heard."

Looking incomparably more haggard than he had three days earlier, the Divine Physician continued.

"While preparing the technique and monitoring the patient's condition, I discovered something strange. The Scorching Yang Qi, which should have been growing more rampant, was gradually subsiding."

"Then isn't that a good thing? What does some sudden poison have to do with—"

"We have not even performed the technique yet. How could the Scorching Yang Qi be decreasing on its own?"

"That…"

"Did you not notice anything strange?"

At that moment, a thought flashed through my mind.

During our journey from Henan to Sichuan, I had periodically stabilized Jeok Cheongang's qi with True Qi Guidance. Yet despite my efforts, his Scorching Yang Qi had continued to diminish.

I thought he was simply growing weaker.

The Divine Physician sighed when he saw my expression harden.

"When one type of energy gains the upper hand, the opposing energy naturally diminishes. But the patient was different. His Yin-Cold Qi remained unchanged, while his Scorching Yang Qi was gradually dwindling."

"Are you saying that was because of the poison?"

"I do not know how it happened, but a Formless Ultimate Poison lies hidden within the patient's body—one that even I would not dare touch. Whether by great fortune or terrible misfortune, the rampaging Scorching Yang Qi happened to envelop the Formless Ultimate Poison and counteract it like poison against poison. Otherwise, he would have melted into a handful of bloody liquid long ago."

"…!"

I didn't know when or how the poison the Divine Physician called Formless Ultimate Poison had entered Jeok Cheongang's body.

But I understood one thing clearly: the Scorching Yang Qi was acting as a breakwater, holding back the spread of the poison.

"Then… then does that mean even the technique cannot cure him?"

"The Life-Restoring Great Technique can regulate his qi and untangle his disrupted qi and blood, but it is not enough to detoxify a poison like this. If we perform the technique as things stand… the Scorching Yang Qi will be calmed, but there will be nothing left to stop the poison."

I shouted urgently, "I'll find an antidote! The Sichuan Tang Clan is here, isn't it?"

"…Young Master."

The Divine Physician shook his head, his expression dark.

“I know very well that the Sichuan Tang Clan is the greatest authority under heaven when it comes to poison. But this poison…”

His voice trailed off, and my heart seemed to drop into my stomach.

Even the Sichuan Tang Clan isn’t enough?

Damn it. This was a truly fucking awful situation.

Right now, Jeok Cheongang had two savage wolves inside his body, each keeping the other in check.

If either one disappeared, the other would regain its freedom and run wild.

And now there was no way to detoxify the poison.

This is so fucked…!

Tap. Drip.

Drops of blood fell from my tightly clenched fist. My throat burned as though I had swallowed a fireball.

Just as I struggled to hold back the curses threatening to burst out, someone’s voice pierced my ears.

“There is a way.”

I opened my eyes and saw the boy’s face. Mungyeong continued, looking more serious than I had ever seen him.

“Let us go to the Sichuan Tang Clan.”

The Divine Physician looked at his Disciple with a dark expression.

“Mungyeong. As you know, this Formless Ultimate Poison…”

“I know, Master. I clearly remember you saying that the Tang Clan’s poison arts focus on killing and that their detoxification techniques are lacking. But…”

Mungyeong looked straight at me with clear eyes.

“If the Sichuan Tang Clan possesses a legendary treasure—a divine artifact said to detoxify any poison under heaven—then it is possible.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest, Myriad-Poison Ring, has been generated!

Chapter 344

Ding.

SYSTEM

Chain Quest, **Myriad-Poison Ring**, has been generated!
There is something you must accomplish. You cannot refuse!

I stared at the holographic window that filled my vision along with the System notification.

SYSTEM

Quest
Myriad-Poison Ring
The Myriad-Poison Ring, said to absorb any poison under heaven, is a sacred artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan and one of the legends passed down through the Murim.
Its owner and even its existence are uncertain, but for now, it is the only possible solution!
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Acquire the **Myriad-Poison Ring**—Incomplete
Reward: A large amount of EXP
Failure: Jeok Cheongang's death

"A sacred artifact said to absorb any poison."

Mungyeong nodded at my mutter.

"That is the Myriad-Poison Ring's ability. However, there is one problem…"

"Its owner and even its existence are uncertain."

"Yes. The Sichuan Tang Clan has denied the existence of the Myriad-Poison Ring several times."

The Divine Physician added in a heavy voice, "That is why it is a legend. It is so ancient that it has survived only through word of mouth."

After thinking for a moment, I suddenly opened my mouth.

"No. It exists."

"Hmm?"

"The Myriad-Poison Ring definitely exists. It's just being kept hidden."

"How can you be so certain?"

Both the Divine Physician and Mungyeong, who had first brought up the Myriad-Poison Ring, stared at me with wide eyes.

“Obviously because…”

Because of the System.

This was a Chain Quest to treat Jeok Cheongang.

If the Myriad-Poison Ring truly did not exist, a Quest like this would never have been generated.

Of course, if I said that out loud, they would definitely think I was insane.

I smoothly continued, “If word got out that they possessed a sacred artifact like that, do you think people would leave them alone? The Sichuan Tang Clan is famous throughout the Murim for being stubbornly insular. Naturally, they would want to avoid the trouble.”

This was a world where people killed one another over a single coin or a dumpling. If the treasure in question were something like the Myriad-Poison Ring, just imagine how many flies would swarm around it.

It was a hastily improvised explanation, but convincing enough that everyone nodded.

“That makes sense. In fact, after conducting an extensive investigation into whether the Myriad-Poison Ring truly exists, even our sect—”

I looked at Gung Gibang, who had jumped in as though he had been waiting for the chance.

“Forget it. Stay here and tell Mujin the rest.”

“Huh? Stay? You want me to stay here with Hyuk Mujin?”

“Captain, what do you mean?”

“What do you think I mean? Exactly what you heard.”

I pointed at the two bewildered men in turn.

“Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang are staying here.”

“Why? Why me?”

“I want to go with you too! Please, don’t leave this vicious beggar and me behind!”

“What?! You dog-bone bastard!”

Smack! Smack!

Sometimes, a good beating was the best medicine. I shook my fists at the two men as they clutched the tops of their heads.

“Stop talking nonsense and stay here to guard Venerable Myoryeong. If anything happens, Gung Gibang, you contact me immediately.”

“Contact you? Is there a messenger pigeon here that can fly to the Sichuan Tang Clan?”

“What kind of beggar’s-foot-rag nonsense is that? If something happens, you come running so fast your feet catch fire.”

“What the hell?”

“If you don’t like it, tame one. I saw plenty of butterflies in the flower garden.”

It was a conclusion I had reached after a brief but coolheaded analysis.

Hyuk Mujin’s martial arts were the weakest among us, especially his movement technique, so I would leave him behind and keep Gung Gibang with him as a precaution against any unexpected situation.

Gung Gibang was a reasonably capable Peak master, and he was as quick on his feet as he was on the uptake. He should be able to handle any unforeseen crisis.

“Anyone dissatisfied with my decision or curious about something, raise your hand immediately.”

“Put that fist down before you ask.”

“I’ll just stay here.”

At that moment, an arm shot into the air. Cheongpung asked with an innocent expression, “What about me, Benefactor?”

“You’re coming with me to the Sichuan Tang Clan, Cheongpung.”

“Why?”

“Who knows what kind of trouble you’ll cause if I leave you behind? Don’t leave my sight even for a moment. Got it?”

“Yeees…”

At Cheongpung’s dejected reply, the Divine Physician spoke with pity in his eyes.

“Do not scold him too harshly. He seems like an innocent young man.”

“He is innocent. Innocent enough to start a forest fire and burn this whole place to the ground.”

“Hoho, surely he would not go that far.”

“I’ll wager Mujin’s left wrist that within a few days he’ll burn down your whole cottage, leave you homeless, and drive you into joining the Beggars’ Sect.”

“…!”

The Divine Physician studied Cheongpung with a wary expression before answering.

“It would be best if he came with us.”

“A wise choice.”

“Gyeong, what will you do?”

Mungyeong thought deeply for a moment, then nodded as if he had made his decision.

“I will accompany you, Master. The Emei nun should have no trouble as long as she gets some rest.”

“I would appreciate that.”

The person I needed most right now was actually the Divine Physician. But having Mungyeong with us would be even better. He was always at his Master's side, serving as a capable assistant.

Besides, he was the one who had first brought up the Myriad-Poison Ring.

The only thing left is figuring out how to obtain it.

Myriad-Poison Asura Tang Sadok. The answer would become clear once I faced the head of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

Once I had finished thinking, I turned to Cheongpung.

"Cheongpung, grab two A-frame carriers and two ropes. Make them big and sturdy."

"Benefactor, why do we need the carriers and ropes?"

"We need to get there as fast as possible. It'd be a disaster if we dropped either of them along the way, so we'll tie them down tight."

The Divine Physician's and Mungyeong's faces turned deathly pale.

In the dark main hall, it was a long while after the middle-aged man entered before the old man spoke.

"More than fifty years ago, before you were even born, our family suffered a great humiliation. Do you know about it?"

At the Myriad-Poison Asura Tang Sadok's words, the middle-aged man lowered his head.

"How could I not?"

"This old man was barely twenty at the time, and I witnessed it all with my own eyes. Our people died all around us, the armory burned, and the pavilions collapsed. We were defeated and forced to withdraw from Sichuan."

The Great War raged for ten long years before ending in victory for the orthodox faction. The Tang Clan returned to Sichuan and rebuilt, but the scars from that time had been carved deep into everyone's hearts.

"And yet, and yet, how!"

The instant green light flashed in Tang Sadok's eyes, the middle-aged man held his breath as poisonous energy poured from Tang Sadok's entire body.

"Hngh."

"How can we suffer such humiliation again?"

Sssssss!

Tang Sadok's wrinkled hand pressed down on the table—or rather, melted it.

Not only the wood but even the iron fittings along the corners liquefied into black poison and flowed. The middle-aged man immediately prostrated himself.

"Please calm yourself, Family Head!"

Despite the middle-aged man's plea, Tang Sadok's anger did not easily subside.

His fury was only natural. Instead of finding the culprit who had harmed his father, Poison King Tang Taesang, he had come up empty and been forced to return after receiving an urgent message from the Qingcheng Sect.

"Who dares…!"

The message sent by the Qingcheng Sect had been brief. It had also been as shocking as the Poison King's death.

He killed Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun and three Emei Elders all by himself.

And it had not been a surprise attack targeting a single person. It was said to have been a head-on fight.

Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun was a Supreme Peak master who could have vied for even the lowest seat among the Ten Kings. The three Elders with her were also seasoned Peak masters.

The culprit had single-handedly brought down the leadership of an entire sect, then vanished like a ghost.

There can't be two masters of that level. It must have been the same bastard who harmed Father.

As his anger slowly subsided, wariness took its place.

He had decided to return not as a son but as the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan. At the same time, he had not forgotten to pursue the culprit.

"What became of the Green Shadow Squad?"

"They divided into ten groups of five and scattered from Chengdu toward Qingcheng, Emei, Yishan, Sanhe, and the surrounding areas to carry out their missions."

Even within the Sichuan Tang Clan, the Green Shadow Squad specialized in intelligence gathering and assassinating key targets.

They had been chiefly responsible for eliminating countless fiends immediately after the Great Faction War, but Tang Sadok felt an inexplicable sense of foreboding.

"Do not let your guard down. Strengthen the defenses of the Gate Guard Pavilion, and do not allow anyone to enter."

"Yes."

"You may leave."

Tang Sadok watched the middle-aged man turn away cautiously, then suddenly spoke.

"Once this matter is over… hand the position of Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion to someone else and move to the Inner Hall."

"F-Family Head?"

“I’m saying this as your uncle, not as the Family Head. You’re nearly fifty. How long did you think I would leave my only nephew at the Gate Guard Pavilion?”

“Th-Thank you, Uncle.”

Tang Sadok answered with a flick of his sleeve.

His nephew was not exceptional, but neither was there anything particularly lacking in him.

Tang Sadok had grown numb with time and lived for many years without thinking about it. Only recently had he begun remembering his elder brother, who had lost his life during the Great Faction War.

“I suppose I’m growing old too, Father.”

At Tang Sadok’s quiet monologue, spoken after he was left alone, his chest rose and fell. Then something slowly poked its head out.

Hiss. Hiss.

It had a body as white as snow, blue eyes, and a triangular head crowned with two horns. It was a snake.

A spiritual creature known throughout the Murim as the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, it was notorious for its ferocity. It flicked out its long tongue and licked Tang Sadok’s cheek.

“You little rascal…”

Tang Sadok’s stiff expression slowly softened.

He had a prickly personality and disliked meeting people, but he made an exception for this Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake.

It was the first and last gift he had ever received from his father, the Poison King. Since Tang Sadok had no children of his own, the snake was more precious to him than anything.

“Hey, that tickles. You little thing.”

He was watching the snake’s antics with a faint smile when the sound of approaching footsteps grew louder.

The white body hurriedly slipped back inside Tang Sadok’s robes.

“What is it?”

“Family Head, it’s me.”

At the voice of his nephew, who had left only moments earlier, Tang Sadok affected a frown.

“Why have you come back?”

“Well, those people have come again.”

“Those people?”

“Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi Jin Taekyung and Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung.”

“I explicitly ordered that no one be allowed inside. Refuse them entry.”

“But… one of them may be the Divine Physician.”

“What? The Divine Physician?”

For once, even Tang Sadok could not hide his surprise.

Who was the Divine Physician? A man said to have reached the divine realm through his medical arts. A mysterious figure who had not shown himself for many long years.

Why had that very Divine Physician come to our family?

His hesitation did not last long. A hoarse voice escaped Tang Sadok’s lips.

“Let them in.”

“Are you the Divine Physician?”

Now that was some no-brakes macho-man talk.

Tang Sadok had asked the question out of nowhere without even pretending to look at us, and the Divine Physician let out a hearty laugh.

“This old man’s name is Dong Feng.”

“Then you are not the Divine Physician?”

“People have given this old man an undeserved name.”

“Seems you are, then.”

“You believe me rather easily.”

“Unless someone is desperate to die, no one tells lies in front of this old man.”

“…”

That was pretty damn convincing.

Tang Sadok slowly looked us over, a green glow shimmering in his eyes.

“The Divine Physician… You, whom the whole world has searched for without catching even a glimpse of you, have come looking for me. And you have brought young prodigies of the Murim with you. Why?”

“May I answer that?”

I stepped forward, and Tang Sadok’s gaze collided with mine in midair.

“Go ahead. If you say something nonsensical, be prepared to become a handful of blood…”

“Please lend me the Myriad-Poison Ring.”

At my own macho-man-with-no-brakes delivery, Tang Sadok’s pupils trembled.

Chapter 345

No matter how much the Murim was a veritable death zone crawling with murder and violence, people in every field learned to observe some decorum once they reached the upper ranks.

Especially when you were the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, one of the Five Great Families.

Tang Sadok might have been comfortable speaking bluntly, but he was not accustomed to others doing the same to him.

As I was doing now.

“Please lend me the Myriad-Poison Ring.”

“…!”

The request struck him completely out of the blue.

His eyes twitched for a split second before he spoke.

“You still believe that ridiculous nonsense? I knew you were young, but you truly are a child.”

“I saw your eye twitch just now.”

“Nonsense!”

“Your voice gets louder when I hit a nerve, doesn’t it?”

“I told you it doesn’t exist!”

“Oh, now you’re clenching your fist.”

“I said I don’t have it!”

“If I search your pockets and find it, can I keep it?”

“Fine! Search me! If you don’t find it, I’ll take your head instead!”

“Oh, so you hid it somewhere else. In that case, I withdraw my request.”

“Grrr…!”

“What a loss…!”

“You insolent little bastard!”

Ah. I probably should have held back that last one.

After being hit by a fantastic barrage of combo attacks, Tang Sadok’s eyes rolled back.

I hurriedly shouted before he could scatter his hidden weapons.

“I only need to borrow it once! Just once!”

“I told you it doesn’t exist!”

“Fine, let’s say it doesn’t. Just hear me out.”

“Nothing you say will change my answer.”

“Even if I offered to deal with the culprit?”

“What?”

“The man who harmed Great Hero Tang Taesang, the Poison King.”

The next moment—

“You little brat! I’ve tolerated enough of your insolence—!”

Whoosh!

Green qi rose from Tang Sadok’s entire body like a shimmering haze. He glared at me with blazing eyes, then spoke in a low, cold voice.

“Do you truly wish to die?”

“I have a bright future ahead of me, so not particularly.”

“Punishing that man is our family’s responsibility. How dare an outsider like you —!”

Whoom!

An aura like a raging gale erupted and shook the pavilion. I stepped in front of the trembling Divine Physician and Mungyeong before answering.

“And how has that worked out?”

“…!”

“The culprit is a master powerful enough to defeat the Poison King. He also evaded the Tang Clan’s eyes here in Sichuan and caused a bloodbath at the Emei Sect. Martial prowess clearly isn’t his only strength.”

Sichuan might have been vast, but the Tang Clan had been rooted here for countless years.

This was no different from losing track of a family enemy in their own front yard. Tang Sadok had led most of his family in pursuit, only to return empty-handed. His expression hardened.

“Are you accusing our family of incompetence?”

“Of course not.”

If the Sichuan Tang Clan was incompetent, most of the sects scattered throughout the realm might as well bolt their gates and withdraw from the martial world.

The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were the giants supporting the Murim. The problem was not that the Sichuan Tang Clan or the Emei Sect was incompetent.

The culprit was simply a monster.

“I’m only pointing out a possibility.”

“A possibility?”

“His martial arts are comparable to the Ten Kings, and he’s exceptionally skilled at escaping. Wouldn’t more people helping you improve the chances of catching him?”

“Our Green Shadow Squad is already pursuing him. I merely returned for a short while to prepare for any unforeseen circumstances. Before long, I will hunt him down and kill him.”

Tang Sadok's sharp gaze swept over Cheongpung and me.

"We are the great Sichuan Tang Clan. We have no need for outsiders' help. Least of all from greenhorns like you."

"…Ah. Right."

Hadn't I already left the level of a mere young prodigy far behind?

Especially that guy.

I glanced at Cheongpung, who was blankly watching the exchange, and scratched the back of my head.

Well, I expected something like this.

Considering the Sichuan Tang Clan's family tradition of doing everything their own damn way, his response came as no surprise.

That was why I had thought up a more enticing proposal on the way here.

"Then instead of greenhorns who came crawling out of nowhere, how about the Fire King?"

"…!"

"Let's say you somehow track the culprit down. He isn't going to hold out his arm and ask you to hurry up and stick poison needles into his veins."

One side would fight to survive. The other would fight to kill. A fierce battle was inevitable.

If the Sichuan Tang Clan committed its full strength, they might succeed in avenging the Poison King—but they would also have to brace themselves for enormous losses.

Countless members of the Tang Clan, whether from the direct line or the collateral branches, would die.

"Old Master—no, my Master—and the rest of us will help you. We'll minimize the Sichuan Tang Clan's losses and leave the culprit's punishment to you, Family Head."

"…Impossible. No matter what losses we must endure, this must be accomplished through our family's own strength."

"Your answer came half a beat late."

"This is the path our ancestors took—the path our family has walked all these years. It is what made the Sichuan Tang Clan what it is!"

"I know. I know what path the Sichuan Tang Clan has walked."

They were a close-knit family bound by blood. They never forgot a grudge, and their vengeance was merciless.

That was the path the Tang Family had walked—and the reason people both respected and feared them.

I continued quietly.

“But no one will point fingers at you for taking a shortcut once in a while. Especially if you choose that shortcut to reduce the number of family members who must be sacrificed.”

Tang Sadok bit down hard on his lip.

Perhaps he was not as coldhearted as he appeared.

No. Even if he was, he was not the sort of ruthless Family Head who would put revenge above everything else.

If he were, he wouldn’t have returned to the family.

But the Myriad-Poison Asura[1735] Tang Sadok had returned. He had come back to protect his family from even the slightest possible danger—to protect those left defenseless in his absence.

“What will you do?”

A long silence passed before his answer came.

“…If—and I mean if—the Myriad-Poison Ring exists, can you treat Great Hero Jeok?”

“Someone I know says it can.”

At my glance, the Divine Physician spoke.

“Our preparations are nearly complete. If we have the Myriad-Poison Ring, there will be no problem treating him.”

“How long will it take?”

“Fifteen days. Fifteen days will be enough.”

“Fifteen days…”

Tang Sadok let out a low groan, then looked at the Divine Physician.

“I examined Great Hero Jeok’s condition once before. Though my medical knowledge is shallow compared to my expertise in poison arts, I could not determine what sort of symptoms he was suffering from. Is it truly possible?”

“It is possible.”

A clear voice rang out.

Mungyeong stepped forward and added a single sentence.

“The Divine Physician can do it.”

“What an audacious boy. Is he your Disciple?”

The Divine Physician answered Tang Sadok’s question with a faint smile before speaking.

“The Myriad-Poison Ring is essential if the patient is to recover. I understand your desire to conceal such a sacred artifact, but I ask that you show compassion and extend us your benevolence.”

“Benevolence, is it? Do you think the same?”

[1735] An *asura* is a powerful, often warlike being in Hindu and Buddhist traditions; here it forms part of Tang Sadok’s epithet.

"Why are you asking me all of a sudden?"

"Speak. I want to hear your thoughts."

"If you insist."

I shrugged.

"Rather than benevolence, let's call it gratitude and grudges."

"Why?"

"Because this is the Murim. If someone helps you, isn't it the way of the martial world to repay them?"

A faint smile touched the corner of Tang Sadok's wrinkled mouth.

"That is far more pleasing to hear."

"It sounds better, and it isn't empty flattery."

"What will you do if the culprit flees to some distant foreign land while Great Hero Jeok is being treated?"

"I'll chase him down myself and bring him back. Ah, I'm not saying I'll leave right away, of course. I won't budge until my Master wakes up."

"You're an amusing bastard. Even tearing the culprit limb from limb wouldn't be enough, but he is also an extraordinary master. Do you think a wet-behind-the-ears brat like you can capture someone like that?"

"If I can't take him alive, I'll kill him."

"Ha… Hahahaha!"

Tang Sadok burst into uproarious laughter. When it finally subsided, he tossed out a casual remark.

"The Myriad-Poison Ring does not exist."

"…What?"

What the fuck was he talking about?

Had this old man been playing me the entire time?

As the back of my head went numb, Tang Sadok continued.

"The Myriad-Poison Ring is nothing more than an old legend. Even among our blood relatives, it is merely a stale tale."

"What do you mean, it doesn't exist? It really doesn't?"

"No one knows, and no one must ever know."

"Fuck! Then you should have said that from the beginning! Have you been messing with me this whole—"

Ssssss.

I snapped my mouth shut before I could finish.

A pure-white snake had slowly crawled out of Tang Sadok's robes and was staring fixedly at me, its tongue flicking.

What is that?

What was he, Voldemort?[1736] *Why was a snake suddenly coming out of his clothes?*

It even had horns, which no normal snake had. As I stared into its black eyes, the Divine Physician murmured in disbelief.

“A Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake…?”

Even the name sounded lethally venomous.

Tang Sadok laughed quietly when he saw me edging backward and stroked the snake’s triangular head.

“Don’t be afraid. It isn’t dangerous, so there’s no need to retreat.”

“Its name sounds fucking dangerous.”

“Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake?”

“Yes. What kind of name is that? It’s not like you’re calling it a golden retriever. Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake… Never mind. Does the Myriad-Poison Ring really not exist?”

“It isn’t called Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake. Its name is Mimi.”

“What?”

“Tang Mimi. That is the name I gave it.”

What was that supposed to mean? Terrifying…

As Tang Sadok lovingly stroked Mimi-chan,[1737] he suddenly looked at the Divine Physician.

“You must know that this creature is no ordinary Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake.”

The Divine Physician nodded.

“As far as I know, a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake is a rare venomous creature that carries an extremely deadly poison. Its entire body is black, and its temperament is so ferocious that it can never be tamed. However…”

“As you can see, this one looks different and has an exceptionally gentle disposition.”

“But we do not know when it might suddenly turn on us. Is it not a venomous creature capable of killing a hundred cows with a single drop of its venom?”

“There is no need to worry. This one has no venom.”

“What?”

“To be precise… it would be more accurate to say that its venom is gone.”

With that, Tang Sadok met Mimi-chan’s[1738] gaze—or rather, the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake’s.

It lasted only a moment, but they had clearly communicated. The clever snake had understood its master’s intentions.

[1736] Voldemort is a villain in the *Harry Potter* series closely associated with snakes.

[1737] *-chan* is an affectionate Japanese suffix used with names, including the names of pets.

[1738] *-chan* is an affectionate Japanese suffix used with names, including the names of pets.

Hiss! Ssssss!

The snake lowered its head and let out a metallic hiss before spitting something onto Tang Sadok's palm.

With a soft plop, the object emerged from the slime covering it.

That's...

A ring.

Set into it was a black gemstone that seemed to contain all the darkness in the world.

Having absorbed even the deadly venom of the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, it gleamed with a beautiful yet ominous light.

"No way..."

As I stared at the ring in a daze, Tang Sadok's low voice reached my ears.

"Remember this. No one knows, and no one must ever know."

"Then..."

"Yes."

Tang Sadok held it out to me.

"This is our family's sacred artifact."

The moment I took the ring with trembling hands, the chime I had been waiting for rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest Condition complete: Myriad-Poison Ring Acquired!

Chain Quest Myriad-Poison Ring has been successfully completed!

Chapter 346

I examined the small ring closely. It was light and strange.

Its band was made of some unknown metal and covered in unfamiliar patterns. The gemstone set in its center gleamed darkly, as though it held the night sky within it.

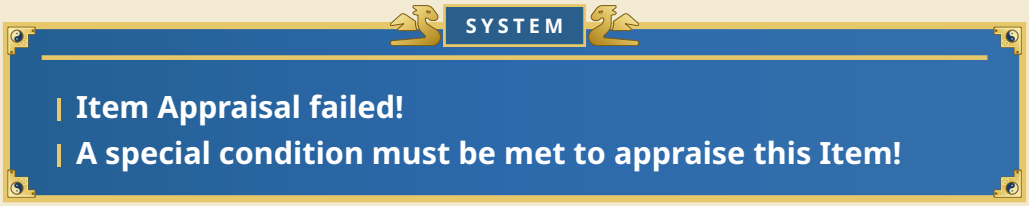
So this is the Myriad-Poison Ring.

The sacred artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan—said to detoxify any poison—had fallen into my hands.

Its power had to be genuine if it could turn a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, a creature said to harbor an extraordinarily deadly venom, into a pet snake named Mimi-chan.[1739] Still, it couldn't hurt to check.

Item Appraisal.

Beep.



"Huh?"

"What is it? Is there a problem?"

I vaguely brushed off Tang Sadok's puzzled question.

"No. It's just…"

"Just what?"

"The gemstone is pretty. It's almost the same color as the snake's eyes."

A crease formed on Tang Sadok's forehead.

I had momentarily forgotten that the old man standing before me was not only the Family Head of a great clan, but also a seasoned martial artist who had spent his entire life in the Murim.

Sure enough, Tang Sadok's eyes widened as he bellowed.

"What nonsense!"

"Family Head, the thing is—"

"Our Mimi's eyes are prettier!"

"What?"

"And that's not all! I rub her down with fragrant oil every morning and evening, so she smells wonderful. Her teeth are pearly white too!"

[1739] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi's name.

"Ah… right."

A seasoned martial artist, my ass. He was just a snake fanatic.

What kind of Family Head liked his pet snake more than his family's sacred artifact?

At this point, I was starting to wonder whether Mimi-chan[1740] was the true sacred artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

But why can't I appraise it?

I tried Item Appraisal again just in case, but the result was the same. If appraising it required some special condition, then I supposed a sacred artifact really was a sacred artifact.

It bothers me that I can't confirm its effects, but it should work.

I turned to the Divine Physician. He had been watching with a smile, and he spoke as though he'd been waiting for me.

"The Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake is no ordinary venomous snake, but a spiritual creature. Yet the ring rendered even its venom glands useless… We will have to try it before we know the full extent of its power, but it is certainly worthy of the name Myriad-Poison Ring."

"In that case…"

"Without the Myriad-Poison Ring, the chance of success would have been a mere one percent. Now, I would place it above seventy percent."

"Even with the Myriad-Poison Ring, it's only seventy percent…?"

"This old man's medical arts will supply the remaining thirty."

"Whew. You should've said that from the start."

The Divine Physician laughed heartily at my sigh of relief and stroked his beard.

"Now only one thing remains."

"What is it?"

"A place to conduct the treatment."

Tang Sadok abruptly cut in, his tone blunt.

"Have you forgotten where you are?"

"I am well aware that the Sichuan Tang Clan has its own clinic. However, treating Great Hero Jeok requires two specific conditions."

"Name them."

"First, it must be secluded, somewhere people cannot easily come and go. Second, it must receive no sunlight and be permeated by a bitter, bone-chilling cold."

"Somewhere secluded, dark, and cold…"

Tang Sadok considered this for a moment, then let out a quiet laugh.

"As it happens, I know the perfect place. I shall take you there myself."

[1740] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi's name.

“Thank you for your generosity, Family Head.”

“I am no benevolent Great Hero. This is merely a matter of gratitude and grudges between us. And if you ever reveal the existence of the Myriad-Poison Ring or allow word of it to spread outside the clan…”

I sighed and finished for him.

“I’ll be dragged off, dunked waist-deep in a vat of poison, and have holes punched through me with needles.”

“You have a poor imagination. Whatever you can imagine, you will suffer worse.”

“That won’t happen unless I lose my mind.”

“I certainly hope so… What are you doing here?”

Good question. What was that guy doing?

While we were talking, Cheongpung had crept over and was reaching toward Mimi-chan.[1741]

“Wow, she’s pretty. Can I touch her?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“Hmph. Do you think she lets just anyone touch her? If I had not summoned her, she would never even have shown herself before you.”

“Mimi, Mimi. Come here.”

“What ridiculous nonsense—”

Hisssssss.

Mimi-chan[1742] slithered down Tang Sadok’s shoulder and licked the back of Cheongpung’s hand.

“Gasp!”

“Mimi, Whirlwind!”

Whirlwind, my ass. He was ordering her to perform a technique even a person wouldn’t understand.

As expected, there was no telling what went on inside Cheongpung’s head.

Sssshk, sssshk, sssshhhk!

“…What the fuck?”

What had I just witnessed?

My jaw dropped as Mimi-chan[1743] began spinning wildly in a tight spiral.

“Wow! Good job, Mimi!”

[1741] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi’s name.

[1742] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi’s name.

[1743] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi’s name.

"This can't be! How could Mimi use Whirlwind on someone she's never met before?"

"Wait, that's a real technique?"

"That is not what matters right now!"

It seemed pretty important to me. At this rate, I wondered whether she might start firing a Thunderbolt or a Hyper Beam.[1744]

Can she evolve too…?

As I tried to decide whether the Myriad-Poison Ring or Mimi-chan[1745] was the true sacred artifact, Cheongpung beamed.

"I'm good with animals. When I lay in the grass at Huashan, birds, deer, and even tigers would come play with me. Hehe."

What was he, some kind of Huashan druid?

Tang Sadok had been staring blankly at Cheongpung, still reeling from the shock of losing Mimi-chan[1746] to him. Now he raised an objection.

"Wait. Something strange slipped in at the end. Why would there be a tiger? How dare you tell such an obvious lie before this old man!"

"We were all about to say goodbye when the tiger tried to eat the deer, so I knocked it out with Crouching Tiger Fist!"

"…"

"…"

It sounded completely insane, no matter who heard it.

Which probably meant it was true.

Silence filled the main hall, making Mungyeong's mutter ring out with unusual clarity.

"Is the Huashan I know a different Huashan…?"

I didn't know about that, but one thing was certain.

If heaven and earth were ever overturned and Cheongpung somehow became Huashan's Sect Leader, from that day onward, it would be *your* Huashan—not mine.

"…Let's go. You said you would show us the place."

"…Very well."

Following Tang Sadok, we arrived at a cave on the distant outskirts of the Sichuan Tang Clan's grounds.

[1744] Thunderbolt and Hyper Beam are moves from Pokémon.

[1745] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi's name.

[1746] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity. Here it is attached to the snake Mimi's name.

Its entrance yawned open like a pitch-black maw.

Aside from two large braziers on either side, there was no one in sight.

“Where are we? It doesn’t look like anyone is guarding this place.”

“If no one is here, I suppose it must be feeding time.”

“Feeding?”

“You will understand once we enter. Follow me.”

Unlike the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s training hall, this cave did not run in a straight line.

We descended stone steps leading deep underground for what felt like ages. Eventually, we reached a narrow corridor barely wide enough for two people to pass through side by side, and a familiar smell invaded my nose.

Is this… the smell of blood?

A bad feeling came over me. I looked around and saw barred iron doors spaced along the corridor.

“Don’t tell me…”

“That is correct. This is our family’s underground prison.”

“…Not a torture chamber?”

“Oh, you will see plenty of those farther inside.”

What the hell had I just heard?

Everyone turned to stare at Tang Sadok, myself included, but he continued as though it were no big deal.

“Except for the Family Head’s Hall and a few other pavilions, this is the oldest space in the family compound. It must be well over two hundred years old by now. In any case, it is a historic place steeped in history.”

Forget its venerable history. I felt like I ought to leave a will before I got dragged any farther inside.

The more I thought about it, the more ridiculous it seemed.

“Isn’t it still just a prison?”

“Is that a problem?”

“Of course there is! You want us to treat Old Master—no, my Master—in here?”

“Not a single ray of sunlight reaches this place, and the chill permeates it to the bone. There is no more suitable location.”

“You said you conduct torture here, too.”

“Of course. Is that even worth asking?”

“…”

Anyone listening would have thought he was asking whether I wanted extra toppings on my pizza.

Just as I ran out of words, a hunched old man came limping toward us from the distance, accompanied by a faint glow.

“Family Head, what brings you here?”

“Ah, Old Man Gung. You’ve been working hard. How are they?”

“Oh, much the same as usual. I just checked whether they were still breathing. But who might these people be…?”

“They are guests of our family. Circumstances require them to stay in the prison for fifteen days. It won’t be too noisy, will it?”

“No, sir. Those still alive are little better than walking corpses, so it should be quiet.”

“When I saw him a few months ago, that Heavenly Power Demon fellow still seemed full of energy.”

“Ah, him? You needn’t worry about that one anymore.”

The hunched old man grinned, revealing a mouthful of almost entirely rotten teeth.

“He made such a racket that I drained every last bit of energy out of him. And since I was at it, I took a few other things too. Hehe.”

“You are always working hard.”

“Oh, Family Head, you flatter me. I only do it because I enjoy the work.”

As I listened to their conversation, I made a firm resolution.

I must never make an enemy of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

After exchanging a few more words with Old Man Gung, Tang Sadok spoke with a bright expression.

“Excellent. It seems the deepest and largest cell has just been vacated. We can use that one.”

I didn’t need to hear why it had been vacated.

It wasn’t as though someone had checked out at the prison’s front desk and walked away.

They must’ve checked in to the afterlife by now.

Even if this place met all the necessary conditions, could we really conduct a medical treatment here?

The Divine Physician had clearly thought the same thing. Mungyeong addressed his Master, who had put on a frown, in a calm voice.

“Master, are we not medical apprentices? For the patient’s sake, we must endure the place even if it displeases us.”

The Divine Physician let out a low groan before answering.

“…Yes. You are right. We shall do so.”

“And the people imprisoned here are certainly evil men who have committed countless murders. Please do not let it trouble you too much.”

Tang Sadok, who had been listening to their conversation, added his own remark.

“Well, well. You are quite composed for such a young medical apprentice. Divine Physician, as the boy said, every man imprisoned here is a thoroughly wicked fiend. Do not think poorly of our family.”

“This old man allowed his concern to lead him into discourtesy. I ask your generous forgiveness.”

“I shall gladly forgive you. Of course, the same does not apply to those bastards who harmed members of our family. Isn’t that right, Old Man Gung?”

Old Man Gung picked up a torch and let out a bizarre, metallic laugh.

“Come, then. This humble one will show you the way.”

“…”

For some reason, I felt as though I were following the Grim Reaper.

Judging by the atmosphere alone, that old man seems more dangerous than the culprit who killed the Poison King.

It had to be my imagination.

Yes. Definitely my imagination.

And so, we began walking toward the suite boasting the finest facilities in the Sichuan Tang Clan’s underground prison.

“Hm?”

The middle-aged man suddenly looked around.

Winter had passed. The sky was clear, and the once-bare mountain forest was slowly regaining its green.

The valley in this nameless mountain was as peaceful as ever. Yet no matter how long he thought about it, he could not understand why he felt such a strange sense of déjà vu.

“How very strange. Very strange indeed…”

The middle-aged man muttered softly, then turned his head and asked,

“Don’t you agree?”

Grrk. Gk.

Blood bubbled up from the man’s gaping throat.

The fallen man glared up at the middle-aged man, his eyes burning with hatred.

“M-my family… will make you pay…”

“What boring last words. Then again, the Sichuan Tang Clan has always been like that.”

Crunch!

The middle-aged man wiped his leather shoe, drenched in blood and brain matter, against the grass before straightening.

Four corpses lay scattered around him.

He smiled at the sole surviving man.

“Now, will you answer my questions obediently, or would you prefer to writhe in unimaginable agony until you die?”

“…!”

“For your information, the Poison King chose the latter. He held out for four days before finally dying.”

The man shuddered, then slowly closed his eyes.

A broad smile spread across the middle-aged man’s lips as he watched the man brace himself for death.

“Good. Let’s find out how long you can last.”

Chapter 347

The Sichuan Tang Clan's underground prison was dark and damp. There was also something about it that sent a chill down the spine.

Perhaps that was only natural. Countless people must have met their deaths here since the underground prison was built.

"Care for a drink?"

In that sense, the old man holding out a worn gourd was practically the Grim Reaper of the underground prison.

I briefly wondered how many people this diminutive, hunchbacked old man had done away with before answering.

"No, thank you."

"If that's what you want, then."

Gulp, gulp.

Old Man Gung tilted the gourd back and wiped his mouth with his sleeve. The sleeve was so worn it looked ready to crumble, and it was covered in dark red stains that looked like blood.

"Ahh, that's good."

The potent scent of liquor drifted through the stench of blood lingering in the corridor and tickled the tip of my nose.

Drinking on duty. At the Jin Family of Taiyuan, that would have earned him a disciplinary report, but apparently that rule did not apply in the Sichuan Tang Clan's underground prison.

"I heard you're one of the most renowned young prodigies in the Murim."

It was obvious who he was talking to. Cheongpung and Tang Sadok had disappeared somewhere early on, while the Divine Physician and Mungyeong were busy purifying the prison and turning it into a treatment room.

I reluctantly answered.

"I wouldn't say I'm that renowned. I can fart a little, though."

"That's not what I heard. As the Fire King's successor, you could piss on the plaques of the Nine Sects and One Gang[1747] and get away with it."

Old Man Gung grinned, baring teeth that had almost entirely rotted away.

"We've got a fellow locked up here who did just that."

"Did what?"

"Pissed on the plaque of one of the Nine Sects and One Gang[1748]. The Kunlun Sect, I believe."

"…There really are all kinds of people in this world."

[1747] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a grouping of major Murim organizations.

[1748] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a grouping of major Murim organizations.

“Heh heh. He was once notorious even among the Demonic Cult’s fiends. Now he’s strapped to a rack, doing nothing but shitting blood. You must have seen him on your way in.”

“Did I?”

The Sichuan Tang Clan’s underground prison was as winding and complicated as a maze. On the way here, I had seen dozens of cells holding more than ten prisoners.

That fellow who pissed on the Kunlun Sect’s plaque was probably one of them.

They were paying the price for their evil deeds. I did not feel even the slightest bit of sympathy for them.

No, it would be more accurate to say that I had no room to worry about something like that.

I didn’t expect to be this nervous.

The peculiar unease I had felt ever since entering the prison refused to fade.

It was the same feeling I’d had several years ago, when my mother went into surgery and I sat in a quiet corridor waiting to hear how it had gone.

It’ll be fine. Everything will be all right.

As I repeated those words to myself, the tightly shut cell door opened and a dozen servants carrying various cleaning tools came pouring out.

I addressed the last person to emerge.

“Is it done?”

The Divine Physician nodded, his expression bright.

In the space of two shichen[1749], the cell behind him had been transformed into a fairly convincing treatment room.

“It is still far from satisfactory, but this should be functional enough.”

“Then…”

“Yes. We begin now.”

At last, all the preparations were complete.

The various medicines made by combining the twenty-four herbs gathered from the Cold-Ice Land had already been brought here. The treatment room was ready. Only one thing remained.

“Thank you all for your hard work. Would you mind giving us the room for a moment?”

At my words, the members of the Sichuan Tang Clan, including Old Man Gung, began to leave. I waited until they had disappeared, then reached inside my robes.

Inventory Open. Summon.

Something hard appeared in my empty palm. I had kept the Myriad-Poison Ring with me for safekeeping, but now I handed it to the Divine Physician.

[1749] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

The Divine Physician accepted the ring, slipped it onto his finger, and entered the prison cell while gesturing to me.

"Would you bring the patient in?"

I lowered the pack frame from my shoulders. A small figure came into view, accompanied by the faintest sound of breathing.

"Over here."

I stepped into the prison cell with Jeok Cheongang in my arms. The floor was clean, but the stench had not completely disappeared and still lingered at the tip of my nose.

None of that mattered, however. The weight of Jeok Cheongang, light as a feather, made my chest ache unusually badly.

You've grown so weak.

A month and a half had already passed since we left the Murim Alliance in Henan and began our journey.

We had found the Divine Physician and secured his treatment far more quickly than I had expected, but Jeok Cheongang had continued to weaken day by day.

Swish.

I carefully laid him on the smooth white stone prepared in the center of the room.

It was a special object called Cold-Ice Stone, provided by Tang Sadok. The Divine Physician had said it would greatly aid Jeok Cheongang's treatment.

"He's sleeping soundly."

Jeok Cheongang's face was gaunt, but it also looked peaceful.

I gazed at his face, covered in wrinkles and age spots.

Memories of everything that had happened since our first meeting flashed before my eyes.

What an interesting kid.

The more I see of you, the stranger you seem. Whose disciple are you?

I clearly remembered the ill-tempered old man I had met at Jang Taebo's house a year ago.

The roof is old. It leaks.

I also remembered the master who, unable to stop the wretched disciple he had cherished like family, blamed a perfectly sound roof as he wept tears of regret.

If you kill that bastard, I'll kill you too.

I entrusted the Fire Gate Clan's sacred artifact to that kid.

I'll pass on everything I have to you.

From Shanxi to Henan, and from Henan to Anhui. Then came the year at Mount Jiuhua. I remembered every moment I had spent with him.

Jeok Cheongang had led me beyond the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and I had followed him out into the vast world. We had always been together.

Well? Just as I told you, wasn't it?

What are you talking about?

The Dance of the Fire God and Demon. Wasn't it incredible?

His face and voice came back to me—the faint smile he wore even while vomiting blood.

Even the single remark he had tossed out on a day when the moon shone brilliantly, while trying to sound gruff.

Master, my ass. Call me Old Master.

"Old Master."

Even when I called out loud, no answer came back.

I knew there wouldn't be, yet I still called to him. Not because I hoped he would hear me, but because there was something I wanted to say.

"Did you know?"

I don't, you idiot!

A dry laugh escaped me at the voice that seemed to echo from somewhere. I gripped Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled hand tightly and whispered,

"I've always wanted to call you Master."

I did not know when it had begun. But at some point, I had realized it.

He was my Master, and I was his Disciple.

We had both been quietly turning those words over in our hearts.

"Young Master Jin. It is time."

At the Divine Physician's words, I tore my gaze away from Jeok Cheongang's face.

Then I respectfully saluted the old physician standing there with a composed expression and the young Disciple beside him.

"Please… take good care of my Master."

The two returned my salute.

"I will do my best."

"I, too, will assist my Master and do everything in my power."

Yes. That was enough.

Do everything one could, then leave the rest to heaven.

We had done everything within human power. All that remained was to entrust the outcome to the heavens.

God, Buddha, Allah, the Jade Emperor[1750].

Whoever you are, if you help me just this once, I'll never forget it.

I did not believe in gods, but I did believe there was some omniscient and omnipotent being above the heavens.

[1750]The Jade Emperor is a deity in Daoist tradition.

As I offered a brief prayer to that being whose face and name I did not know, the Divine Physician spoke solemnly.

"Remember this. Fifteen days—fifteen days. Until then, no one may approach."

What should I do if it takes longer than fifteen days?

I swallowed the words hovering on the tip of my tongue. Now, I had no choice but to trust the two of them. There was only one thing I could say.

"I'll stop anyone who tries to enter, even if I have to stake my life on it."

"Is that everything?"

The middle-aged man looked down at his victim with impassive eyes.

The man's limbs were bent at grotesque angles, and his skin had been flayed away. Reduced to a blood-soaked ruin, he wheezed in a voice as faint as an ant's.

"I—I've already told you everything I know…"

"Aren't you leaving out the most important part?"

"I don't know. I truly don't."

Bloody tears streamed from his one remaining eye. His trouser legs, already drenched in blood, darkened further with urine.

The man forced out a trembling voice.

"Please… just kill me now…"

The middle-aged man stared into the man's fading eye, then clicked his tongue.

"It seems you really are telling the truth."

The man had already endured half a day of unimaginable torture.

If he had begged for his life, there might still have been room for doubt. But now that he was begging for death, the middle-aged man had no choice but to accept it.

Until now, no one had ever lied to the middle-aged man.

No one except the Poison King, Tang Taesang.

"I've seen the extent of your half-day's courage. You may rest now."

Whoosh—thud!

Along with the sound of a single gust of wind, the blood-soaked head jerked backward. A flick of the middle-aged man's finger had pierced the man between the brows, and he died with a peaceful expression.

The middle-aged man stared down at the body of the man who had been a member of a collateral branch of the Sichuan Tang Clan and an operative of the Green Shadow Squad. Then he stretched out a hand.

Boom!

A thunderous roar rang out as a pit one zhang[1751] deep opened in the ground.

[1751] A Chinese zhang is a traditional length of about 3.33 meters, or 10.9 ft.

The five corpses scattered nearby were neatly stacked inside it and covered with earth, all within moments.

"The Green Shadow Squad… So those gnats have latched on."

Muttering under his breath, the middle-aged man looked beyond the winding mountain ridge. West, toward the Sichuan Tang Clan.

I should have killed Tang Sadok when he came out.

That had been a mistake. The Poison King's resistance had been fiercer than expected, and purging the poison had taken considerable time. It had even cost him an arm.

Emei or Qingcheng might have been another matter, but the Sichuan Tang Clan was exceptionally vigilant and heavily defended. Even for him, storming the place alone after losing an arm would be too much.

But his life has only been extended by a few days. The outcome will not change.

He had long since grasped every movement taking place in Sichuan.

All preparations were complete to hunt the three tigers crouching in Sichuan—Emei, Qingcheng, and the Tang Clan.

Now…

It was time to summon the hunters.

Whoosh!

The middle-aged man moved as though gliding. Distance vanished with every step, and the scenery swept past him.

At last, he stopped before a cliff deep in the mountains.

"This is the place."

Without hesitation, the middle-aged man reached out and placed a hand against the cliff.

The next instant—

Vwoom.

A resonant hum rang out, and the cliff collapsed.

No. It would be more accurate to say that space itself had warped. The weathered stones and boulders vanished, revealing a vast hollow concealed behind them.

The sorcerers' Mystic Gate Formation. It never stops being impressive.

But compared to what he was about to do, even this was nothing more than a parlor trick.

Step. Step. Step.

The middle-aged man strode into the darkness blanketing the hollow. At its heart, he stopped in the center of a strange pattern carved into the floor and drew upon his internal energy.

A dark red haze poured from his entire body.

The instant it touched the pattern—

“Lord of Heaven!”

Flash!

At the middle-aged man’s cry, the pattern blazed to life. A black flash—dark yet bright, impossible to describe—filled the entire hollow.

Then the light vanished, and a thunderous chorus filled the space it left behind.

“We pay our respects to the Western Heaven Demon Lord!”

“We pay our respects to the Demon Lord!”

Hundreds of tiger hunters stood before him in pitch-black robes, their eyes devoid of emotion and their auras sharp as blades.

A faint smile touched the lips of the middle-aged man—the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Chapter 348

The black-robed men stood in neat ranks and files. The sheer number of them—several hundred—was not the only thing filling the enormous cavern.

It was their aura.

The suffocating aura emanating from the men—their eyes deep-set, their bodies upright as iron towers—was swallowing the cavern.

And towering over them all stood one man—a giant in his own right.

“Third Fiend.”

Vwoom.

His voice, infused with profound internal energy, bored into the black-robed men’s ears. They shuddered, and the three old men at the front were no exception.

They stepped forward several paces, then prostrated themselves at the middle-aged man’s feet in perfect unison.

“The juniors of the Qilian Mountains pay their respects to the Western Heaven Demon Lord.”

Their faces, builds, and voices—everything about the three old men was astonishingly alike.

They were brothers born from the same womb.

Their mother had died giving birth to them, and their father had abandoned his young children and left. Stranded in the barren land of Qinghai, the three brothers hid near the vast mountain range to escape the scorn of others.

Then, one day, after everyone had forgotten them, the brothers returned.

They returned as the Qilian Three Fiends.

“You’ve aged quite a bit since I last saw you. I suppose I could call you the Three Old Men now.”

“N-no, my lord. How could the likes of us be called old while you are here?”

The Qilian Three Fiends had once been fiends who dyed Qinghai Province red with blood. Yet before the Western Heaven Demon Lord, they were nothing more than docile lambs.

The Qilian Three Fiends swallowed hard, then opened their mouths at the same time, as if they were one person.

“B-but, my lord. Forgive us for saying so, but your arm…”

“This?”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord looked down at the empty sleeve where one of his arms should have been and answered in a dry voice.

“It was the price I paid for two lives.”

“Does that mean…”

“The two old fossils from the Tang Clan and Emei are no longer of this world.”

"…!"

The air inside the cavern trembled with agitation.

Who were the Poison King and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun? They were giants who had left their mark on the history of the Murim, Supreme Peak masters who had dominated an entire era.

And yet…

Both had met their end at the hands of a single man.

The Qilian Three Fiends and the black-robed men stared at their leader in awe.

"Th-then…"

"Yes."

A fierce light flashed in the Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes.

"The time has finally come."

Right now, my eyes are closed.

I focus my mind in the quiet darkness. As a voice pierces my ears, someone's figure takes shape in the darkness.

Neither tall nor short, the young man hiding claws behind an innocent smile is Cheongpung.

"First, I'll use Crouching Tiger Fist to target my Benefactor's shoulder, chest, and stomach in that order."

The imaginary Cheongpung moves through the darkness.

Fast.

He erases the distance in a single step and rushes in, his fist blurring. I can almost hear the fierce whistle of air being torn apart.

"I can dodge that easily. I'll retreat half a step diagonally and throw a punch at your flank."

"I'll use Chaotic Flower Hand to redirect your force as I retreat, then counter with Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords."

"What form?"

"One Cut Under Heaven."

One Cut Under Heaven was among the most powerful supreme forms of the Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords.

Even back when Cheongpung and I had sparred regularly, I had chosen to evade that technique rather than block it.

"Isn't that a little excessive?"

"Given who my opponent is, I have to give it everything I've got."

"What happened to calling me Benefactor?"

"That's one thing, and this is another. Hehe. Anyway, One Cut Under Heaven."

One Cut Under Heaven.

It wasn't difficult to imagine how the attack would come.

In the darkness, Cheongpung uses Chaotic Flower Hand to redirect my force and retreat without taking the blow. The instant his hand reaches his waist, a flash bursts forth.

Sshk!

With a spine-chilling hiss, Sword Energy surges out horizontally.

I can see it vividly before me.

What should I do?

I don't have to think long.

"I'll deflect it. First form of the Fire Dragon Divine Spear—Fire Dragon's Single Tail."

"You won't be able to block it."

"When was the last time we fought?"

"Hmm. About a year ago."

"If you think about it one way, that's short. If you think about it another, it's a long time. It was long for me. Long enough for a single day to feel like ten years."

"…!"

"Think again. Are you sure I can't block it?"

Cheongpung was silent for a moment before answering. His voice had sunk low.

"I was wrong. If it's you, Benefactor… I think you can."

"Then let's continue."

Cheongpung and I devoted ourselves to discussing martial arts for a long while.

It had been more than a year since we had actually crossed hands, but from the Star-Array Grand Banquet until now, we had come to know each other's martial arts and skill levels well enough to make this possible.

"Three steps to the left. Plum Blossom Five-Point Finger."

"Plum Blossom Five-Point Finger is an excellent martial art, but it won't matter as long as I protect my vital points. I'll follow you in and strike your chest with Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist."

Within the scenes we each imagine, the battle surges back and forth.

One hundred exchanges. Two hundred.

Before long, our imagined bout passes five hundred exchanges. Then Cheongpung suddenly speaks.

"I'll use Dark Fragrance Drift to close to within two steps, then Plum Blossom Three-Ridge Sword."

All of a sudden?

Cheongpung was weaker than me in close combat. He had learned Huashan's outstanding supreme martial arts, but perhaps because the sect's roots lay in sword techniques, the Fire Gate Clan had a slight advantage when it came to palm techniques.

And yet he was coming in this close…

Ah. So that's it.

I had suspected as much, but this was Cheongpung, all right.

I opened my eyes with a hollow laugh. When I didn't answer for a long while, Cheongpung cautiously opened his eyes to a narrow slit and asked,

"Benefactor, why?"

"That's enough for today."

"Ah! Why?"

"Because it would be a shame."

"What?"

"Let's fight for real later. Not through a discussion like this. Let's actually cross weapons."

It would be too unsatisfying to decide the outcome through an imagined exchange. I meant that we should settle it later with both of us fighting at full strength.

Cheongpung was as innocent as a child, but by no means stupid. Surely that was enough for him to understand—

"Why would we cross weapons? Wouldn't they collide?"

"…"

No.

Maybe he really was just an idiot.

While I regretted my hasty judgment, Cheongpung began pestering me.

"I'm bored, Benefactor. Can't we keep going?"

"Oh, Cheongpung. Did you hear about that?"

"About what?"

I gazed intently at Cheongpung and parted my lips.

"I heard there's a former imperial chef at the Sichuan Tang Clan."

"An imperial chef?"

"Apparently, his cooking is incredible. Especially his pastries and sweets."

Gasp.

Cheongpung's eyes glazed over for a moment, but he soon shook his head vigorously.

"N-no. I have to stay here with you and watch over Grandpa Jeok."

"It's fine. I'm staying here anyway, so—"

"Then I'll be back!"

"…Sure. Go ahead."

Whoosh!

What was that? Some kind of bullet movement technique?

Once Cheongpung had vanished at the speed of light, I looked around.

A bleak chill and a foul stench permeated the underground prison. I hadn't taken a single step outside since the treatment began.

"It's only the fourth day."

The words escaped me like a sigh.

Time passed far more slowly in the underground prison than I had imagined. Not because the place never saw a ray of sunlight, but because of the anxiety and tension felt only by those who were waiting.

Perhaps that was why every day felt like my blood was drying up.

"Maybe I should have stayed in front of the treatment room."

Even as I said it, I shook my head. There was nothing I could do by pacing in front of the treatment room door anyway.

With my five senses already sharpened to their limit, I would only listen to every sound coming from inside until I could no longer bear it, then retreat and pace through the underground prison at a distance.

Just as I was doing now.

Still, it's awfully quiet now that I'm alone.

With Cheongpung, who had stuck to me like glue for the past three days, suddenly gone, I felt strangely empty.

Tang Sadok had forbidden even Old Man Gung from entering the prison, so I was completely alone now.

No. Come to think of it, I'm not alone.

I wasn't talking about the Divine Physician and Mungyeong, who were probably completely absorbed in treating Jeok Cheongang.

There were ten or so prisoners trapped in the underground prison, waiting for the day they would die.

They were my roommates.

Not exactly the best roommates, though.

They weren't the kind who left the toilet unflushed or constantly brought their lovers over. Every one of them was a fiend who had earned a notorious name throughout the martial world.

Even if they were imprisoned, there was no way sharing a space with men like that could be enjoyable.

And the most troublesome part was…

Dong. Ddong. Ddeeeong.

I'm the one who has to feed them.

I frowned at the familiar tolling of the bell.

With Old Man Gung gone, someone had to make sure the prisoners were still alive and bring them their meals.

That someone was me.

The bell that had just rung was the signal from outside announcing mealtime.

At least it's only once a day.

Still, bothersome was bothersome. I sighed and started walking.

In a corner of the prison, a battered old wooden barrel awaited me, filled with scraps of food haphazardly mixed together.

It had been poured down through a hole connected to the surface. Calling it a meal was generous. It was basically a slop bucket.

No one's around, so I guess it's feeding time.

There was a reason Tang Sadok had used the word *feed* three days ago.

The Sichuan Tang Clan treated the prisoners here like dogs and pigs.

No, dogs and pigs had it better. At least livestock didn't have to worry about surprise visits from Old Man Gung carrying an assortment of torture implements and wearing an eerie smile.

"Heave-ho."

Adopting the mindset of a zookeeper, I carried the slop bucket around the prison.

Beyond the thick iron bars, prisoners sat with their arms and legs bound in steel chains. All I had to do was open each door, step inside, scoop up a heaping ladleful, and dump it into the battered bowl set before them.

Whenever I did that, the prisoners, who had been lying limp and helpless after prolonged imprisonment and torture, would make their eyes flash and strike up a conversation.

"Never seen your face before."

"You've been seeing me for three days. What kind of bullshit is that?"

"Release me. I'll teach you martial arts that can look down on all under heaven."

"Judging by the fact that you're rotting in here, they sound like martial arts the whole world can look down on."

"You insolent bastard… The moment I get out of here, I'll tear you apart and kill you myself."

"Oh, impressive. I'll be sure to pass that along to Old Man Gung."

"Please! Anything but that!"

The attempts to win me over never stopped.

Some offered to teach me their martial arts. A middle-aged beauty who had once drained the vital essence of the Tang Clan's direct line through a technique of harvesting yang to replenish yin even tried to seduce me.

"Child. Why don't you come a little closer? I'll show you heaven."

"Kirara Asuka. Grandma Uehara."[1752]

"…What?"

"The mainland still has a long way to go compared to the island nation. Stop talking nonsense and eat your damn food."

"You little—Hey! You turtle bastard!"

I ignored her spiteful shouting and headed toward the last prison cell.

In the most secluded and damp corner was a strange man with disheveled hair.

He's the quietest old man in this prison.

He was also the most dangerous.

The severed sinews and meridians in his limbs and the restraints several times heavier and sturdier than those of the other prisoners were proof enough.

Rattle. Thump.

The old man stared silently at the bowl of unidentifiable food before suddenly speaking.

"I heard you talking about this old man."

I stopped short.

Not because it was the first time I had heard his voice in three days, but because I had no idea what he meant.

"Talking about you? When did I do that?"

"Three days ago. Did that Gung fellow not mention me?"

"Gung fellow? Old Man Gung?"

I searched my memory for a moment, then looked at the old man with newfound surprise.

"Oh. Then are you the one who pissed on the Kunlun Sect's signboard?"

"Yes. This old man is the Heavenly Power Demon—"

"So you were the Kunlun Sect's public-pissing criminal."

"…"

The old man—the Heavenly Power Demon—had an eyelid that twitched.

[1752] A reference to Japanese adult-film performers Kirara Asuka and Ai Uehara. Taekyung mangles the names, replacing *Ai* with *noin*, Korean for "old person."

Chapter 349

After a brief silence, the Heavenly Power Demon spoke.

"…A public-urination criminal? Do not call this old man by such a disgraceful name."

Ah. My mistake.

It seemed the fiend who had once spread his infamy throughout the world found that title rather unpleasant.

After giving it some thought, I offered him a more appropriate alternative.

"Hmm. How about bedwetter?"

"Y-you little…"

"If you don't like that, then *The New Nation's Little Pisser*.[1753]"

"This old man did not wet himself!"

"Then *He Who Peed. A Midsummer Night's Pee*, featuring the Kunlun Sect.[1754]"

"…!"

I clicked my tongue at the Heavenly Power Demon, who couldn't even come up with a response.

"I don't know what got into you and made you start talking all of a sudden, but I don't want to hear it, and I don't want to talk to you. So eat your damn food and relieve yourself to your heart's content. Shit, piss, or both at the same time. Whatever you want."

"W-wait."

Good grief. What a pain.

I had finished handing out the food and was about to leave the underground prison when I turned around with an irritated scowl.

"What?"

"There is something I wish to ask."

"And if you have something to ask, am I obligated to answer?"

But the Heavenly Power Demon, seized by an inexplicable desperation, refused to back down. Wearing scraps of what might once have been called clothing, he opened his mouth with a gleam in his eyes.

"The Divine Cult. What has become of the Divine Cult?"

"The Divine Cult?"

"Yes, the Heavenly Demon Divine Cult!"

"Oh. The Demonic Cult."

The different names used by the two sides had confused me for a moment.

[1753] This plays on the title of a Korean children's song, "Children of a New Nation."

[1754] "He Who Peed" plays on the Korean rapper San E's name. "A Midsummer Night's Pee" parodies the title of his song "A Midsummer Night's Sweetness."

To most Murim warriors, myself included, it was *your* Demonic Cult. But to members of the Demonic Cult, it could only be *our* Divine Cult.

Especially for the Heavenly Power Demon standing before me. Wasn't he a fiend whose notoriety had once been considerable even among the Demonic Cult's members?

"What, have you been locked up so long that you're feeling homesick?"

"Tell me."

"That's easy enough."

I gave a short laugh and continued.

"I don't know either."

"…What?"

"How would I know what the Demonic Cult is doing, holed up all the way out there? If a new inmate from the Demonic Cult ends up in the cell next to yours, ask him."

The Heavenly Power Demon stared at me as if he couldn't understand.

"Are you not the Fire King's successor? Yet you claim to know nothing about the Divine Cult?"

"…How did you know that?"

"My dantian may be ruined, but these old ears still work."

"You're remarkably spry for your age. How much do you know?"

"Only that the Fire King is here to have his injuries treated."

"Hmm."

He was a rather perceptive old man.

Cheongpung had mentioned Jeok Cheongang's name several times, but never loudly enough for the other prisoners to hear. Even if the Heavenly Power Demon had overheard him, it would have been difficult to infer the circumstances from those conversations alone.

He keeps his mouth shut and his ears open.

He was different from the other prisoners, who tried every possible trick to win me over the moment they saw an opening.

I found myself growing slightly interested in the old man before me.

"But why are you so curious about news of the Demonic Cult? You've been imprisoned for ages."

"It has been forty-odd years."

"The Great Faction War had already ended around then. Don't you have a general idea of what happened?"

"A general idea?"

The Heavenly Power Demon smiled bitterly.

"Few people know the Divine Cult better than this old man."

"Sounds like you pissed on things there too."

"This old man was once an Elder of the Great Heavenly Demon Divine Cult. It was I who obeyed the august command of the Cult Leader, subjugated Qinghai, and fired the opening shot of the holy war."

"Holy war, my ass."

Despite my curt response, I was secretly surprised.

He's a bigger deal than I thought.

From the bits and pieces I had picked up, the Demonic Cult had immensely powerful fiends known as the Ten Elders or the Seven Elders or something like that.

I had assumed he wasn't an ordinary fiend after hearing that he'd pissed all over the Kunlun Sect's signboard. But I had never imagined that the shabby old man waiting to die in an underground prison had once been an Elder of the Demonic Cult.

"You knew nothing about this old man, I suppose."

"Of course not. That was ages ago. Today was the first time I'd even heard the title Heavenly Power Demon."

"…Heh. Has it truly been so long already?"

As the Heavenly Power Demon let out a hollow, self-mocking laugh, I leaned against the prison wall.

"So what does a former Demonic Cult Elder from forty years ago want to ask me?"

"Tell me everything you know about the Divine Cult. Every piece of recent news, without adding or omitting anything."

"I don't know. Something about this feels off."

"This old man has already passed his ninetieth year. Both body and spirit are exhausted. This is the final request of an old man who has already been given his day to die."

"The request of a fiend who committed all kinds of atrocities, you mean."

"Atrocities… I will gladly pay for the lives I have taken. But what, exactly, makes something demonic? The Divine Cult and your people opposed each other for many years, each standing by its own convictions. We merely lost the struggle in which we staked our fate. That is all."

The Heavenly Power Demon continued in a clear voice, almost lamenting.

"Can that alone determine who was right and who was wrong? The world back then was like a powder keg that could explode at any moment. Had your side crossed Gansu and Qinghai first and reached the Divine Cult, you would have slaughtered our followers beneath the paltry excuses of serving the greater good and rooting out evil at its source."

"But from what I've heard…"

"Boy."

His quiet voice silenced me.

A pair of eyes blazed more fiercely than ever as they stared into mine.

They were not the eyes of an old man whose martial arts had been completely crippled, waiting for the day he would die.

They belonged to a general and Supreme Peak master who had once led an army and swept across the world.

"This old man saw it with his own eyes and experienced it firsthand. I saw how cruel men could become in a war of killing and being killed. Neither the followers of the Divine Cult who cried out for holy war nor the Sect Leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang[1755] who called for the extermination of demons were exceptions. Even…"

At that moment, the fire in his eyes died away. Only his bitter voice remained, scattering through the air like ash.

"Even the Cult Leader was no exception. He lost the convictions with which he had begun and fell into corruption. Yes. Perhaps, as you orthodox faction warriors claim, the Divine Cult truly had become a Demonic Cult."

The Heavenly Power Demon's words left my thoughts tangled.

In a way, what he had just said aligned with something I had recently come to understand.

Good people and bad people exist everywhere.

The Demonic Cult and the orthodox Murim had been at odds for ages, each holding a match as they watched the other across a powder keg ready to explode.

The Demonic Cult had ultimately been the one to light the fuse. But what if the orthodox faction had struck the first match?

Would the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword have spared ordinary Demonic Cult civilians who knew nothing of martial arts?

No way.

For a moment, those two men overlapped with the Heavenly Power Demon in my mind.

Who was white, and who was black? Was there something unknown hidden in the history that had already passed?

Damn it. I don't know.

I bit my lip hard and pulled my back away from the cold wall.

"There's no point telling me any of that."

The Heavenly Power Demon nodded weakly.

"…I know. Nothing is more futile than speaking of a past already gone."

[1755] A collective name for major orthodox martial-arts sects and the Beggars' Gang.

“And I’m not as knowledgeable about the Demonic Cult as you think. If that well-informed beggar were here instead, he might’ve been able to give you the news you want.”

“Did the Divine Cult fall?”

“I don’t know. Apparently not. From what I’ve heard, it has managed to survive somehow.”

Dark Heaven’s name had drawn so much attention lately that it was easy to forget, but the Demonic Cult remained the orthodox Murim’s eternal archenemy.

And with a possible connection between the Demonic Cult and Dark Heaven now under suspicion, the Murim Alliance headquarters in Henan was probably busy investigating both.

“I did hear that the Demonic Cult suffered devastating losses in the Great Faction War and shrank to a shadow of its former self.”

The Central Plains was not called the center of the world for nothing.

Unlike the orthodox Murim, which had recovered a considerable portion of its losses by absorbing the region’s abundant resources, goods, and population like a sponge, the Demonic Cult had been forced into the Tianshan Mountains while bearing the full weight of its tremendous losses.

“…Of course. It was a war in which the Divine Cult mobilized its full strength.”

He muttered under his breath, a self-mocking smile touching his lips.

“Heh. We once swallowed half the world, and now we are reduced to this pitiful state. I should have stopped the Cult Leader, even at the cost of my life, when he accepted vicious criminals like the Qilian Three Fiends and the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts. Then again, that was when the Cult Leader himself began to change.”

“The Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts?”

“You may not know of them, but long ago, there were men called—”

“Oh, I know them.”

“What? You know the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts?”

I nodded as if it were obvious.

“I don’t know much about the Qilian Three Fiends, but I know the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts.”

“How can someone who has never even heard this old man’s title know of the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts?”

“Well, you see…”

I scratched the back of my head and continued.

“I tend to remember the title of anyone I’ve fought. Especially masters of that caliber.”

“…W-what? You fought the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts?”

“Technically, I only fought one of them—the Yang Ghost. Our Old Master—no, Master—killed the Yang Ghost. The Yin Ghost was killed by some crazy bastard and followed his friend to the afterlife. Anyway, do these fucking bastards think Henan is Gotham City…?”

“…!”

The Heavenly Power Demon froze with his mouth hanging open, then hurriedly poured out his questions.

“T-the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts! How did those men survive and reappear in the Murim? And in Henan, no less? Did the Divine Cult launch a surprise attack on Shaolin?”

“They did raise hell at Shaolin, but it wasn’t the Demonic Cult’s doing.”

“Th-then who was responsible? Who did it?”

I had expected as much, but the Heavenly Power Demon truly knew nothing about the current state of the Murim.

The only outsider he ever spoke to was Old Man Gung.

Not that the old man is the type to explain things out of kindness.

Not unless he considered severing tendons a form of kindness.

After a moment’s thought, I decided to tell him the truth.

The Heavenly Power Demon had no chance of leaving the underground prison before his death anyway.

Besides, Dark Heaven’s existence had once been top secret, but word was already spreading among the major sects. Telling him would cause no harm.

“Uh, I’m not sure how to put this.”

“Tell me. Quickly!”

“Hold on.”

Ah, right.

At last, I found the perfect term. Impressed by my own brilliance, I opened my mouth.

“They changed jobs.”

“…?”

“I don’t know whether they joined another company or merely transferred to a different department, but until they died, they were working for a group called Dark Heaven instead of the Demonic Cult…”

In the end, I couldn’t finish.

Hurried footsteps approached, and a familiar face appeared.

“B’factor!”

“Swallow what’s in your mouth before you talk.”

“B’factor! B’factor! Try this too! It’s delish!”

“What’s with all the ‘B’factors’? Are you looking for the police chief who lives in Namcheon-dong?[1756]”

“B’factor!”

“Yeah, yeah. I’m sure you went to the sauna, ate together, and did the whole nine yards.”

“It’s weally delish!”

Cheongpung had stuffed both cheeks full of snacks, and he was still carrying an armful of food wrapped in paper.

I pulled out a nicely roasted duck leg and was about to sink my teeth into it when I remembered the man I had momentarily forgotten and held it out to him.

“Want one?”

Only then did I finally see the Heavenly Power Demon, frozen like a stone statue.

[1756]The police chief, sauna, and meal are a reference to a Korean film line in which a gangster boasts of his connections.

Chapter 350

Step. Step.

As always, I made my rounds carrying the slop bucket.

Time moved slowly in the underground prison, yet it passed as steadily as the clock at the Ministry of National Defense.[1757] I was already entering my sixth day down here, and the routine was gradually becoming familiar.

Clank. Screeeech.

I opened the rusted bars and strode into a cell filled with filth and stagnant water.

An old man bound to a torture rack greeted me with a sly grin.

“You’ve come?”

He was the Killing Ghost, who had joined the Demonic Cult during the Great Faction War and killed more than a hundred martial artists of the orthodox faction.

Now reduced to a toothless old man, he continued through slurred words.

“I tell you this for the last time…”

I cut him off as I scooped up some slop with a long ladle.

“Didn’t you say yesterday was the last time?”

“This time, it truly is the last.”

“Sure. And tomorrow will be the real, *real* last time.”

I’d been through this countless times over the past six days. It wasn’t even surprising anymore.

The old man flinched at my indifference, then shouted, “You! Become my Disciple!”

“You! Get hit.”

Whack!

The ladle struck him squarely on the crown, and the old man writhed in pain. The chains binding his limbs swayed and clattered noisily.

“Graaaagh!”

“Keep it down. You’re loud.”

“Ugh! You little bastard!”

The old man was about to start yelling at the top of his lungs when his eyes suddenly widened and his nostrils flared.

He had caught the scent of oil beneath the prison’s stench.

“W-what is that smell?”

“Nothing you need to know about.”

[1757] The comparison invokes the passage of time during mandatory military service in South Korea: the clock keeps moving, however slowly it seems to those serving.

“Roast duck. It’s roast duck! Do you have liquor too?”

“What liquor?”

“Liar! That aroma is unmistakably Jiannan Chun!”

“…With a sense of smell like that, you’re on the level of a drug-sniffing dog.”

“Hand it over! Now!”

Whack!

“Graaaagh!”

“It belongs to someone else. Just eat your damn slop.”

I set down the bucket and headed for the last cell.

Far deeper and darker than the others, it held a familiar old monster who was waiting for me.

Clank.

“I brought your meal.”

“…”

“You must have had a hard time waiting. By the way, why is it so cold in here? Your sleeping arrangements must be terribly uncomfortable. Should I ask the Tang Clan to lay down an animal-hide blanket for you?”

“…”

So this was how he wanted to play it.

Despite my soft, gentle tone, as soothing as a cat’s paw, the Heavenly Power Demon remained stubbornly silent.

Ever since what had happened three days ago, he had kept his eyes and mouth firmly closed.

Of course, that wasn’t enough to make me give up.

“Come on, don’t be like that. Try some of this.”

I took out a sheet of grease-stained paper and unfolded it.

A whole duck, coated in spices and roasted to perfection, revealed itself in all its plump glory. As a bonus, its mouthwatering aroma was strong enough to drive away the stench of the cell.

“What is this? It’s roast duck made by a former imperial chef. I tried some myself, and the duck is definitely tender. The flavor is very consistent too.”

“…”

“And roast duck calls for liquor. Jiannan Chun, the famous liquor of Sichuan! Liquor and meat suit a Great Hero like the Heavenly Power Demon, don’t they?”

“…”

A frigid silence settled over the already chilly cell.

I kept smiling brightly at the Heavenly Power Demon as he sat cross-legged. At last, I let out a deep sigh.

“Fuck, I can’t do this anymore.”

For three days, I’d bent over backward to please him. I’d softened my voice, spoken with scrupulous politeness, praised him as a Great Hero of benevolence and righteousness, and kissed his ass shamelessly.

But the Heavenly Power Demon had refused every offer and comfort I provided. No matter how much food or clothing I brought him, he never touched any of it.

“I’ve done more than enough by now. Are you really going to keep this up?”

“…”

“I’m only being this courteous because I’m such a gentleman. What do you think will happen if the Sichuan Tang Clan finds out, huh?”

At that moment, the Heavenly Power Demon finally spoke without opening his eyes. It was the first time I’d heard his voice in three whole days, and it had grown terribly hoarse.

“Do so.”

“What?”

“This old man has endured enough torture to be sick of it. Even if I depart this world, I will have no regrets.”

He had spent more than forty years imprisoned in the underground prison. Faced with his serene detachment, like some enlightened monk, I clicked my tongue.

“Good grief. You really don’t make things easy. Is it really so difficult to tell me only what you know about Dark Heaven?”

“I have said all there is to say. Kill this old man or torture him. Do as you please.”

“No, what kind of old man is this?”

But the Heavenly Power Demon had already sealed his lips again. He probably wouldn’t open them a second time.

“…What a stubborn old man.”

I heaved a sigh deep enough to sink the earth, placed the liquor and roast duck within his reach, and turned away.

“Fine. For now, just eat that. You haven’t had anything in three days.”

Even as I spoke, I knew. Whether I returned tomorrow, the day after, or three days from now, the food would still be exactly where I’d left it, stone cold and untouched.

“Damn it.”

With the Heavenly Power Demon fed—or at least served—I finished my rounds and dropped to the floor in a corridor far from the cells.

The Heavenly Power Demon.

His rigid face and that indescribable look in his eyes kept flashing through my mind. There was no mistaking the agitation those two words—*Dark Heaven*—had stirred in him.

The problem was that he refused to say a word about it.

But he definitely knew about Dark Heaven long ago.

I hadn't heard it directly from the Heavenly Power Demon, but it was already as good as established fact.

The real question was how he knew about Dark Heaven, and how much he knew.

I slowly retraced the conversation I'd had with the Heavenly Power Demon three days ago.

After putting the brain that had earned me seventh-tier school grades[1758] through its paces, I arrived at only one plausible conclusion.

Dark Heaven and the Demonic Cult are deeply connected.

No. They might even be one and the same.

The Heavenly Power Demon had once been an Elder of the Demonic Cult. Even after spending forty years imprisoned and tortured in the underground prison, he had never lost his loyalty to the Cult. His silence was proof enough.

If Dark Heaven were an enemy of the Demonic Cult, he would've talked by now.

Then what the hell was Dark Heaven? Some splinter faction that had broken away from the Demonic Cult? Or another organization created within the Demonic Cult itself?

A branch of Shincheonji[1759] called Sick Shincheonji. Something like that.

Whatever they were, one thing was certain: the bastards were a plague.

I'd been lost in thought for quite some time when Cheongpung appeared with a spring in his step, trailing a sweet aroma behind him.

"Hey!"

"…Your grandpa lives on Lotus Peak at Huashan, right?"

Cheongpung swallowed what was in his mouth before answering.

"No! He's in Henan right now!"

"Yeah, sure."

Why did I even bother talking to him?

The mountain of food piled in Cheongpung's arms left me speechless. I was starting to feel sorry for the former imperial chef, and I'd never even seen the man's face.

"You went out for all this?"

"Yes! And while I was at it, I brought a letter from the Beggars' Sect."

"…Shouldn't that be the other way around?"

"Hehe."

"Don't smile. I'll get attached."

[1758] South Korean school-record grades use a scale on which one is highest and nine is lowest. A seventh-tier grade is poor.

[1759] Shincheonji is a South Korean religious organization.

I answered gruffly and accepted the letter Cheongpung held out.

When I unfolded the grimy paper—wherever he'd been keeping it, it couldn't have been clean—three strands of yellow dog hair drifted out.

A three-knot[1760] Disciple. The branch leader sent it.

Just as I'd expected, the letter was addressed to Gung Gibang from the Beggars' Sect's Chengdu branch leader.

Of course, Gung Gibang was at the Divine Physician's secret refuge, so the branch leader had probably sent it to me for convenience.

A moment later, when I looked up from the letter, Cheongpung asked, "What does it say?"

"Nothing much. They're still searching."

The Beggars' Sect had originally combed through Sichuan with a fine-tooth comb in search of the Divine Physician, but it had since changed targets.

Now it was hunting the culprit who had murdered the Poison King and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun.

Not that a man like that would be easy to catch.

Tang Sadok had initially insisted on settling the matter with the Sichuan Tang Clan's strength alone, but his attitude had changed after he lent me the Myriad-Poison Ring.

Yet even with the Tang Clan's full cooperation, the culprit's trail had vanished like a ghost.

"Do you think they'll find him?"

"Who knows? We'll have to hope for the best. We have the Beggars' Sect, and the Tang Clan's Green Shadow Squad are experts in reconnaissance and pursuit. Surely they'll turn up something."

"What about the government troops?"

"They seem to be pulling their weight too."

Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao, wielded tremendous influence.

Won Gyun, the City Lord of Sichuan Province, had readily agreed to my request to search for the culprit instead of the Divine Physician.

The individual fighting ability of the government troops couldn't compare to that of Murim warriors, but their sheer numbers—several thousand men—couldn't be ignored.

"Wow! Thousands?"

"I don't know the exact number, but apparently they're swarming all over the place. You saw the government troops too, didn't you, Cheongpung? On our way back to the Sichuan Tang Clan."

[1760] In the Beggars' Sect, the number of knots denotes a disciple's standing; more knots indicate higher standing.

"Oh, but there weren't that many when I saw them."

"…Of course not. Did you think thousands of men would all travel together?"

It wasn't difficult to imagine the government troops gathered in groups of three or five according to their assigned formations, stopping and searching people.

> The government troops are gradually expanding their search area and advancing toward Qingcheng and Emei.
>
> They appear to be searching for the culprit while preparing for a possible incident.

I read the last line of the letter and let out a quiet laugh.

They're doing better than I expected.

Won Gyun, the City Lord of Sichuan Province, looked every inch the corrupt official, but apparently he wasn't completely incompetent. Either that, or the military officer in charge of this operation knew what he was doing.

But what if they still can't find him after all this?

I'd talked a big game in front of Tang Sadok, so the thought was seriously worrying.

Of course, Jeok Cheongang's safe recovery came first.

I glanced at the treatment room, whose door remained firmly shut, then casually asked Cheongpung, "What kind of food did you bring?"

"Sho mush!"

"…Finish what's in your mouth. I'll take care of the rest."

Jang Il was a two-knot[1761] Disciple of the Beggars' Sect.

He had become one out of necessity rather than choice. He'd heard a rumor that anyone who formally joined the Beggars' Sect, underwent the initiation ceremony, and became an official Disciple would receive a whole dumpling.

What could an eight-year-old beggar brat who hadn't eaten in four days have known?

Clutching his empty stomach, he had gone to the Chengdu branch and become a Beggars' Sect disciple that very day.

"They only gave me half a dumpling, too. Just thinking about it still makes my teeth grind. Goddamn it."

The beggars listening to Jang Il yawned quietly. They'd already heard the story dozens of times.

[1761] In the Beggars' Sect, the number of knots denotes a disciple's standing; more knots indicate higher standing.

More than ten years had passed, but Jang Il's anger had yet to subside.

"I gritted my teeth over that half dumpling and worked my way up to deputy branch leader. So you lot should…"

As the story showed signs of dragging on, the three one-knot[1762] Disciples exchanged glances.

"Oh! My stomach suddenly hurts!"

"Gasp! Mine too!"

"Ugh, the latrine! Where's the latrine?"

"You little bastards!"

Jang Il shouted, but the three beggars had already bolted.

"Those damn brats… Just wait until they come back."

That was when a group of men caught Jang Il's eye.

Uniform clothing and weapons. Their lack of military discipline was an added bonus. The sight was familiar enough that Jang Il muttered,

"Government troops."

These days, government troops were more common than neighborhood stray dogs.

Normally, they slacked off so thoroughly that no one ever saw them, but now that the high and mighty had stepped in, they seemed to be scrambling to at least put on a show.

They said they were expanding the search area. Are they already this far out?

As he wondered about it, a middle-aged military officer who appeared to be leading the group approached him with a smile.

"Are you, by any chance, a Beggars' Sect disciple?"

Jang Il nodded casually.

"As you can see."

"I thought so when I saw your knots."

"Anyone can tell just by looking. Still, you've made good time. You're already this far out."

"Ah, they say the Beggars' Sect has the finest intelligence network under heaven. I suppose you already knew we were coming?"

"This much is nothing out of the ordinary for our Sect."

The military officer smiled along with the smug Jang Il.

"But there are no villages nearby, and hardly anyone passes through here. Why are you alone?"

[1762] In the Beggars' Sect, the number of knots denotes a disciple's standing; more knots indicate higher standing.

“Don’t ask. The branch leader kept nagging me, so I brought a few men out for some fresh air. Things have been pretty noisy lately with all this talk of a murderer and whatnot.”

“I see.”

“Well then, take care…”

Jang Il never finished.

The moment the officer nodded with a smile, something cold pierced his chest.

Shnk!

…Huh?

Cough.

Jang Il stared blankly at the sword buried in his chest and coughed up blood.

Why? How?

The questions never escaped his lips. His knees buckled as he stared at the officer through clouding eyes.

His face struck the new shoots just beginning to emerge from the earth, and a cold voice reached his ears.

“Find the others. They should be nearby.”

“As you command.”

“Stupid beggar bastard. Why did he have to be here of all places…?”

That was the last thing Jang Il heard.

He was twenty-five years old.

The young beggar died in a secluded forest two days from Emei Sect.

Chapter 351

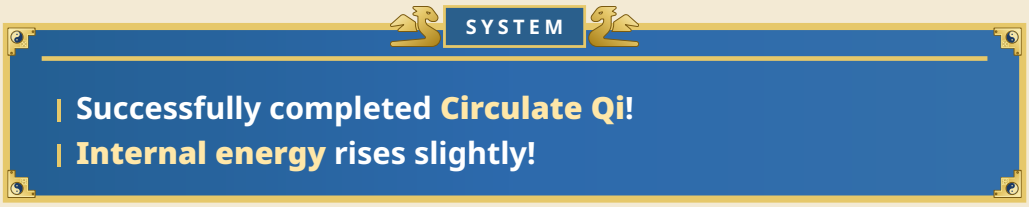
Waiting was nerve-racking, and time crawled by.

If I had been one of the countless twenty-somethings living in twenty-first-century Korea, I might have been half a wreck by now.

After all, I would have had to endure ten days in a gloomy underground prison without a smartphone or Wi-Fi.

But I had something those ordinary twenty-somethings didn't.

Martial arts.



"Phew."

I slowly drew a deep breath and gathered the qi inside me.

While I'd been circulating my qi, Cheongpung—standing guard, my ass; he'd been snoring away beside me—blearily opened his eyes.

"Oh, are you finished?"

"Phewww."

"Benefactor?"

"Phewwwww."

"Benefactor, are you hurt?"

"…"

Why did this guy keep ruining my concentration?

He looked ready to keep asking until I answered, so I reluctantly replied.

"Don't talk to me."

"Why not?"

"I'll lose qi."

There was a reason gym rats constantly went on about losing muscle.

Finishing circulating my qi didn't mean I could simply get up the instant it ended. I also needed time to gather my qi, savor the afterglow, and meditate.

"Oh, I'm sorry."

"Come on. You know all this, don't you?"

Cheongpung scratched the back of his head.

"I didn't know there was anything like that…"

"Huh? Then what have you been doing all this time?"

"I just got up and went out to play when I finished."

“From the very beginning?”

“Yes.”

“…Did Great Hero Mae Jonghak never teach you?”

“Grandpa said that no matter how much dust you gathered, all you’d have was a pile of dust. He said it was more important to spend that time doing whatever I wanted. Apparently, those experiences might eventually provide a clue to enlightenment.”

Was this some kind of YOLO cultivation method?

The more stories like this I heard, the more certain I became that Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was an eccentric.

No, wait.

That guy has more internal energy than I do.

I currently possessed just over a hundred years of internal energy.

That put me far above my peers; it was the kind of level someone could reach only if a prestigious great sect on the level of the Nine Sects and One Gang[1763] committed itself to supporting them.

And I had only managed it because I’d obtained the Blazing Flame Divine Pill and stumbled into various other fortuitous encounters while repeatedly surviving life-or-death situations in the Murim.

So how did Cheongpung have more internal energy than me?

“Elixirs! You ate Huashan’s elixirs!”

Cheongpung’s official sponsors were none other than the Sword Saint and Huashan. If he’d received their help, it wasn’t impossible.

But Cheongpung’s answer to my entirely reasonable suspicion was simple.

“No, I didn’t. Grandpa doesn’t like people coming to visit him.”

“Oh, right. Then how did you build up that much internal energy?”

Cheongpung thought for a moment before answering.

“It just sort of accumulated on its own.”

“…”

“Oh, and when I was little, I often had my sinews cleansed and my marrow washed.[1764] Hehe.”

What the hell? Why was he talking about cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow as if he were merely washing his face?

I stared blankly at Cheongpung as he smiled awkwardly.

This guy really was born a protagonist.

[1763] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a major grouping of martial-arts organizations in Murim fiction.

[1764] Cleansing the sinews and washing the marrow is a martial-arts technique said to improve a person’s constitution.

Natural talent and fortuitous encounters. Everything came so naturally to him that he took it all for granted.

The phrase *I just did it, and it worked* might as well have been invented for Cheongpung.

"What a rotten world."

"Benefactor, what is?"

"Nothing. Just something."

"Yes."

My chest had already felt stifled lately. Now it felt as though someone had piled another hundred sweet potatoes[1765] on top of it.

I'd run into the so-called "wall" that Murim warriors often spoke of, and I had been thinking about asking Cheongpung for advice…

But there's no point asking him.

I had just let out a quiet sigh when—

Grrrrrind.

"…Huh?"

"…Benefactor?"

A heavy scraping sound bored into my ears. Cheongpung stared past my shoulder, his eyes wide, and my heart sank before beginning to pound.

No way. No way.

It's only been ten days.

I slowly turned my head. At the far end of the corridor, an iron door was slowly opening, filling my entire field of vision.

When two people finally emerged, I asked in a trembling voice,

"How… did it go?"

There was no answer.

But that was enough.

The Divine Physician and Mungyeong—the exhausted master and Disciple—were looking at me with radiant smiles.

Smiles bright enough to illuminate the dark underground prison.

"The treatment was a success. There were several difficult moments along the way, but we managed to overcome them safely and finish the treatment sooner than expected…"

The Divine Physician continued speaking, but his voice sounded as though it were coming from far away. Only his first words kept echoing in my ears.

[1765] In Korean slang, sweet potatoes evoke a stifling sense of frustration.

The treatment was a success.

Yes, it had ended successfully. I'd heard the words I wanted to hear more than anything, and that was enough.

Old Master.

Without realizing it, I tightened my grip on Jeok Cheongang's hand.

He still lay there with his eyes closed, perhaps not yet ready to regain consciousness. But I could feel it clearly.

His vitality has returned.

That wasn't all. Jeok Cheongang's appearance had changed considerably over the past ten days. His age spots had vanished, his wrinkled skin had grown taut, and flesh had returned to the body that had been wasting away by the day.

Compared to before, he looked a good ten years younger. No, perhaps twenty.

"Could it be…?"

My voice trailed off as I looked at the Divine Physician.

Noticing the question in my eyes, he smiled faintly.

"Unfortunately, it is not Bone Transformation. However, the medicinal ingredients used during the treatment and the energy of the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng greatly benefited Sir Jeok."

"Oh, I see."

Disappointment and joy washed over me at the same time.

It would have been wonderful if he had used this treatment as an opportunity to advance to an even higher realm, but perhaps I had expected too much for a moment.

"You seem disappointed."

"Oh, no."

Startled, I quickly waved my hands. These two had successfully completed the difficult treatment without a single complaint. It would have been rude to look disappointed.

"I was only…"

"Heh heh. I did not mean to blame you. How could I not understand Young Master Jin's feelings for his Master? Is that not right?"

"Of course. You are absolutely right, Master."

Mungyeong answered politely, then continued speaking to me.

"Sir Jeok will regain consciousness within three days at the latest. The treatment has only just ended, so his qi needs time to settle properly. You need not worry too much."

"Three days at the latest."

“Yes. Of course, even after he awakens, he must avoid exerting himself too heavily for a while. Sir Jeok is renowned throughout the Murim, so he should recover quickly.”

“I’m sure he will. He’s always been overflowing with energy. Then, does that mean everything really is…”

“Yes.”

Mungyeong smiled and nodded.

“The Yin and Yang have regained their balance, and no Formless Ultimate Poison remains. The treatment is over.”

“…Phew.”

I released the breath I’d been holding. All the strength drained from my body, leaving me with the strange sensation that I was floating.

How long had I waited to hear those words?

When my legs gave out and I slumped to the floor, the Divine Physician spoke with a mischievous expression.

“It seems this old quack was not very trustworthy to you, Young Master Jin.”

“N-no, it wasn’t that I didn’t trust you, Old Man Dong. It was just… You know how it is. Cheongpung knows what I mean, right?”

“I don’t!”

“…Never mind. My mistake for asking you.”

The Divine Physician laughed even louder.

He watched us fondly, as though enjoying his grandchildren’s antics, then patted me on the shoulder.

“Everything is fine now. This old man will remain here as a precaution, so put any worries you still have away for good.”

“What?”

The Divine Physician saw my expression and hurriedly waved his hands.

“There is no need to make that expression. I am only staying to watch the patient awaken after treatment.”

“Phew, you scared me. You should have led with that.”

I had thought there was something else left to worry about.

Mungyeong grinned at his flustered Master, then spoke.

“Sorry to interrupt, but I think I should leave now.”

His sudden announcement startled me.

“What? Already?”

“Yes. Venerable Myoryeong should have regained consciousness by now, so I would like to go check on her.”

“You must be tired. Stay and rest for a while.”

“No, it is fine. I hardly did anything anyway. If I still have energy to spare, then as the younger one—even if only by a year—I should be the one to go. Isn’t that right, Master?”

“You little rascal!”

“Hahaha.”

I was worried about him, but it seemed they had already settled the matter between themselves.

No sooner had he finished speaking than Mungyeong slung his travel pack over his shoulder. Watching him, I suddenly remembered something I had forgotten.

“Mungyeong.”

“Yes?”

“Thank you. Truly.”

Mungyeong gazed at me for a moment, and a smile touched his lips.

“That is the finest praise a medical apprentice could receive.”

“Family Head, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi requests an audience.”

Ssssss.

At the voice from outside the door, the snow-white snake slipped back into Tang Sadok’s robes.

Tang Sadok frowned at the interruption to one of the few peaceful moments in his day.

“Jin Taekyung, you mean?”

“Yes.”

“For what reason?”

“He says the treatment is over. And…”

The guard continued, confusion evident in his voice.

“He said he would like to keep using the item he borrowed for a few more days.”

“The item he borrowed.”

“Yes. Those were his exact words. He also asked to remain in the underground prison for a few more days.”

It was an indirect way of referring to the Myriad-Poison Ring. Tang Sadok let out a short laugh and muttered,

“What a brazen brat…”

“Pardon?”

“I was not speaking to you. Pay it no mind. Tell Jin Taekyung I give him permission, and continue watching him.”

“Yes, Family Head.”

Tang Sadok listened to the guard's footsteps fade away and tapped the table.

He was neither a Great Hero of Benevolence and Righteousness who helped others without seeking anything in return nor a chivalrous hero who could not tolerate injustice.

He had lent Jin Taekyung the clan's sacred treasure as part of their bargain, but it was only natural that he would continue keeping a close watch on him.

I am the Family Head of the great Sichuan Tang Clan. I trust no one.

One shichen[1766] earlier, even the young medical apprentice attempting to leave the clan had been thoroughly searched and questioned.

They had only allowed him to leave because his identity was guaranteed. Had he been a Disciple of some ordinary lesser sect, he would not have been permitted to take a single step outside.

In any case, the Fire King's successful treatment is good news. The Divine Physician truly lives up to his name.

Tang Sadok had already heard from his late father that Fire King Jeok Cheongang was an exceedingly eccentric old man.

He had also heard that Jeok Cheongang was so proud that he would repay any gratitude or grudge he incurred, no matter what it took.

You bastard… your days are numbered.

A green glint flashed through Tang Sadok's eyes.

The murderer who had killed his father and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun was definitely said to be one-armed. That was not especially rare in the Murim, but it was not a feature one saw every day, either.

A maimed man stood out wherever he went.

Run. Run wherever you can. The Sichuan Murim will hunt you until the day you breathe your last.

Grind.

Tang Sadok was quietly grinding his teeth when—

"Uncle!"

With an urgent shout, the pavilion doors flew open. Tang Sadok's face twisted at the same instant.

It wasn't the Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion's unannounced intrusion that disturbed him, but the martial artist standing beside the man.

His green martial uniform was torn and covered in blood, and the words *Tang Family* were embroidered across it.

"You…"

There was no mistaking it.

He was a member of the Green Shadow Squad.

[1766] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

A member of the Green Shadow Squad who should never have appeared here in such a state.

Facing the rigid Tang Sadok, the Green Shadow Squad martial artist cried out, blood choking his voice.

“They—they’re coming!”

Chapter 352

They're coming.

The Green Shadow Squad martial artist had blurted out a disjointed sentence.

But insight struck Tang Sadok like a flash of lightning. It gave form to the small unease he had harbored in his heart, and it was the conclusion drawn from all the experience he had accumulated over the years.

The murderer isn't alone!

The one-armed man who had killed his father and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun was coming to the Sichuan Tang Clan with his subordinates.

Who the true mastermind was, how many men they had, and how they had managed to move through Sichuan as freely as their own backyard—none of that mattered now.

The next moment, Tang Sadok's voice erupted like a thunderbolt.

"One Origin, Three Divisions, and Five Squads—prepare to meet the enemy!"

Rumble!

The pavilion trembled beneath the enormous shout, laden with powerful internal energy.

The disturbance had occurred in none other than the Family Head's Hall. The first to react were Tang Sadok's guards surrounding the pavilion.

"Family Head!"

Bang!

By the time the guards burst inside, smashing through the pavilion, the clan members who had heard Tang Sadok's shout were already spreading his orders throughout the family compound.

Within fifteen minutes, hundreds of Tang Family members, united by venomous resolve and resentment, would assemble.

And then…

I'll show you what the Tang Family's revenge looks like.

Despite the fury boiling in his chest, Tang Sadok's eyes had grown as cold as the northern wind and bitter snow.

"Family Head, what in the world is—"

"The men who deserve to die are coming. That is all."

He waved away the bewildered guards and fixed his gaze on the Green Shadow Squad martial artist.

The man's uniform was torn and soaked in blood, unmistakable evidence of battle.

"What happened? Tell me everything you saw and heard. Leave nothing out."

The Green Shadow Squad martial artist finally caught his breath and began his report in an exhausted voice.

“It began when we discovered a suspicious group while searching near the Golden Hall.”

“A suspicious group?”

“Yes.”

“The Golden Hall is barely half a day from our family. The Beggars’ Sect and the government troops have already completed every inspection and search in the area. How could…”

Tang Sadok trailed off, his gaze turning grim.

“…The government troops. It was the government troops.”

The Green Shadow Squad martial artist stared wide-eyed at the Family Head, then nodded.

“Y-yes! They were definitely wearing government uniforms.”

“A disguise.”

Tap. Tap.

Tang Sadok drummed his bony fingers against the table.

They had been caught completely off guard.

The Beggars’ Sect and the government troops had confirmed Chengdu’s safety several times, and it had been only two days since they expanded their search area.

The enemy had slipped into Chengdu through the gap left when the net loosened.

It wouldn’t have been difficult.

The elite were always deployed to the front lines. The most experienced and sharp-eyed members of the Beggars’ Sect and government troops had already left Chengdu.

Besides, wasn’t this after several thousand government troops had spent nearly ten days roaming around Chengdu? Anyone wearing their uniforms could have blended in naturally.

“How many were there?”

“Perhaps to avoid suspicion, they were moving in several groups. But from what we were able to determine, there seemed to be at least three hundred of them.”

“Three hundred?”

“Yes. I’m certain.”

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion had been listening to the report with an anxious expression. Now he spoke in a triumphant tone.

“Ha! Only three hundred? They must have a death wish. Isn’t that right, Uncle?”

“…”

“Our family alone has more than three hundred martial artists ready to fight at a moment’s notice. And that isn’t all. Isn’t this exactly why we built an impregnable

fortress? They won't even make it over the walls before our poison and hidden weapons kill them."

Tang Sadok finally opened his mouth.

"Shut up."

"Pardon?"

"I said shut up."

"U-Uncle, why are you acting like this? It's only three hundred. We could wipe out that many in the blink of an eye…"

"Only three hundred?"

The fingers drumming against the table stopped dead.

Tang Sadok stared at his only nephew with utter contempt.

"You haven't forgotten the Gyeongwol Year Bloodbath, have you?"

"…How could I?"

The Gyeongwol Year Bloodbath was practically taboo within the Tang Clan.

Fifty years ago, the Sichuan Tang Clan had been forced to abandon the land it had occupied for centuries and flee in disgrace.

That day, Tang Sadok had lost his only older brother, and the Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion had lost his father before he was even born.

"But things are different now!"

Tang Sadok answered his nephew's impassioned shout in a cold voice.

"Yes. Exactly what is different?"

"The Demonic Cult's forces numbered two thousand, while our family had only three hundred martial artists!"

"You're more or less correct so far. Go on."

"Although we were defeated and forced to retreat, our family suffered barely more than a hundred casualties, while the Demonic Cult lost over a third of its forces."

"That is also true. Those losses delayed the Demonic Cult's conquest of Sichuan. Our family lost its home, but gained even greater fame in exchange."

"Then why?"

Bang!

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion slammed his fist down, denting the iron table. He glared at his uncle with blazing eyes.

"Why are you afraid of a mere three hundred enemies? Fifty years ago, even the Demonic Cult's vicious fiends—several times more numerous than this—had to shed untold blood to overcome our family!"

His ringing shout shook the air inside the pavilion.

Tang Sadok's answer to his furious nephew was short and simple.

"So? Is that all?"

"…What?"

"You pathetic fool."

Tang Sadok sighed as his nephew's eyes wavered.

"The Gyeongwol Year Bloodbath is a humiliating chapter of our history that must never be forgotten. But it is also the day our family proved its strength to the entire world."

"Y-yes. That is why martial artists throughout the world still praise our family's martial might and righteous spirit."

"Ha… Hahahaha!"

Ignorance this profound was practically a disease. Tang Sadok let out a hollow laugh as he looked at his nephew, who still failed to understand.

"Yes. The entire world knows. Do you think our enemies don't?"

"…!"

"After the Great Faction War, our family built an impregnable fortress that no one could breach. We increased our numbers and armed our clan members thoroughly. Is there anyone under heaven who doesn't know that? Is there anyone who doesn't know the strength and determination our family displayed during the Gyeongwol Year Bloodbath?"

Under the storm and thunder crashing down on him, the Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion's face had turned pale.

Only now did he understand that the three hundred enemies invading the Sichuan Tang Clan were not men anyone could dismiss as *only* three hundred.

By contrast, the old and experienced Family Head's judgment was swift and decisive.

"Sound the Tang War Drum."

A stir passed through the guards, who had been frozen like stone at the Family Head's command.

"Y-you mean the Tang War Drum?"

"Distribute poison and hidden weapons to everyone, regardless of age or sex. Retired elders, craftsmen who have never learned martial arts, women—no one is exempt. Our family will commit its full strength to this battle."

"A-as you command!"

The blade-sharp order wiped the color from the guards' faces. They hurried into motion.

A short while later, when the Tang War Drum's thunder rolled throughout the Sichuan Tang Clan, everyone would know.

Their family stood on the brink of destruction.

And no one felt that danger more keenly than Tang Sadok.

This is dangerous.

The experience and instincts he had honed over years of leading the family whispered a warning.

A sea of corpses and blood surpassing even the Gyeongwol Year Bloodbath might be waiting for the Sichuan Tang Clan.

Then came the sound that announced the beginning of everything.

Boom. Boom. Boom!

The majestic sound alone was enough to set hearts pounding. The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion murmured,

“So this is the Tang Clan drum…”

The Tang Clan drum had not sounded since before he was born. He was still struggling to contain his emotions upon hearing it for the first time when Tang Sadok spoke.

“They beat us to it.”

“U-Uncle?”

The Master of the Gatekeeper Pavilion spun toward him and saw the fathomless depths of Tang Sadok’s eyes.

At the same time, several gray-flecked figures entered the pavilion with swift movement techniques.

“Family Head!”

“It’s the enemy! They’re coming while beating a war drum!”

“They launch an attack while sounding their own war drum. Impressive bastards. Truly impressive.”

Tang Sadok burst into laughter.

The ten people staring at him looked dumbfounded.

“This is no time to laugh!”

“Family Head, please give us your orders!”

They varied widely in appearance. One was a young man who seemed to be in his thirties, another was a graying middle-aged man, and there was even an old man around Tang Sadok’s age.

Whatever their ages, each had proven their martial prowess among the clan’s hundreds of members.

That was why Tang Sadok had given them another name.

“The Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders. Perfect timing. I was waiting for you.”

“Family Head, what in the world is happening? We should attack them at once—”

“You can ask that fellow over there for the details.”

The gazes of the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders followed Tang Sadok’s.

Finding himself under the scrutiny of so many powerful figures, the Green Shadow Squad martial artist swallowed hard.

“I-I’ll tell you anything I know!”

“That is good to hear. Then let this old man ask you…”

Tang Sadok continued in a gentle voice.

“Weren’t you one-armed?”

“…!”

“…!”

At that moment, time seemed to stop.

The majestic thunder of the Tang War Drum, which had finally begun to sound.

The frantic movements and shouts of the clan members.

Unlike the time outside, which continued to flow unchanged, everything inside the pavilion had come to a complete halt.

Amid the silence and shock, only one person moved backward through time.

Crack. Crrrck.

Bones lengthened and contracted. Muscles swelled.

The blood-soaked uniform tore apart, splitting the two characters embroidered across its chest—*Tang Family*—in half.

The Green Shadow Squad martial artist slowly rose to his feet.

He was no longer a young man in his twenties.

Nor was he a member of the Green Shadow Squad.

“You have a sharp eye. The Poison King raised his son well.”

The middle-aged man smiled faintly and rubbed his left arm. The color of his skin differed subtly around the elbow, as if the arm had been removed and attached again.

“And to answer your question… I honestly don’t know myself. Let’s just call it demonic martial arts for convenience.”

A green light flickered in Tang Sadok’s eyes as he stared at the middle-aged man.

“So it was you. You were the one who harmed my father.”

“Poison King Tang Taesang truly lived up to his reputation. I was honestly impressed. That was when I lost my arm, too.”

The middle-aged man clenched and unclenched his left fist, making a show of frowning.

“The sensation still isn’t quite what it used to be. I wonder if I’ll ever fully recover…”

“Do not worry. This old man will personally cut off your head so you never have to concern yourself with it again.”

“We’ll lend a hand as well.”

Rumble!

The enormous qi pressure flowing from Tang Sadok and the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders shook the pavilion.

Yet even in the face of deadly poison capable of killing a person with a single breath, the middle-aged man—the Western Heaven Demon Lord—smiled calmly.

“If you can, by all means.”

Roar!

Chapter 353

Boom. Boom. Boom!

Listening to the thunderous drumbeats, an old man muttered,

“It’s been a while since I heard that.”

He was short and stocky, with coarse, unruly features. To ordinary eyes, he was nothing more than an ugly, ill-tempered old man.

But anyone who had faced him even once called him by another name.

Fiend.

The old man curled the corners of his mouth upward. Seeing the wet-behind-the-ears pups waiting for him atop the walls surrounding the Sichuan Tang Clan like an impregnable fortress, roughly three hundred yards ahead, put him in an excellent mood.

“I can almost smell the blood already. This is how I felt when we first came down from the Qilian Mountains.”

He had come into the world after a difficult birth, cursed with ugly features.

How could his two brothers, born from the same womb on the same day, have been any different? When even their father disappeared, the three brothers had nowhere left to turn. Fleeing the contempt of others, they hid in the Qilian Mountains.

“We were so young back then. Bastard or bitch, we killed them all, then killed some more…”

They had been born into an age of chaos, and so they became fiends.

By the time they finally looked around, everyone who had despised their ugliness and pelted them with stones lay submerged in pools of blood.

Then they joined the Demonic Cult’s invasion of the Central Plains and stained the world red. People came to know and fear them as the Qilian Three Fiends.

“Remembering our prime is exhilarating. Don’t you think?”

The old man, the First Fiend, turned his head with a smile, only to click his tongue when he realized his mistake.

“Good grief. Maybe it’s because I’m getting old, but I keep forgetting things.”

The two younger brothers who had followed him like shadows their entire lives were not here.

The Second Fiend had left to take charge of Qingcheng, while the Third Fiend had gone to take charge of Emei.

Before long, the two famous mountains counted among the greatest in the world would be covered in a sea of corpses and blood.

And then…

Kwahhhhhng!

At last, the signal announcing the beginning of everything rang out.

The First Fiend let out a hearty laugh at the thunderous boom coming from beyond the walls of the Sichuan Tang Clan. The time promised by the Western Heaven Demon Lord had arrived.

“The Demon Lord is calling us. Don’t you agree?”

Shing-shing-shing!

Hundreds of weapons were drawn, slicing through the dawn air.

Behind the First Fiend stood three hundred black-clad men in a long formation. They had already discarded their government-troop uniforms and donned black leather armor.

“The time has come. Raise the flag!”

The instant the First Fiend’s shout rang out, the Tang Clan martial artists atop the walls saw it.

Flap.

A flag rose high beyond the pale dawn mist.

Two characters billowed in the fierce wind.

“Dark Heaven…?”

Someone on the wall muttered the words, but the booming drums swallowed them.

Boom. Boom. Boom!

The drumbeats grew stronger, and the black-clad men began to advance in time with them.

Hot breath spilled from between their lips, but their eyes were cold. Razor-sharp killing intent rolled off their bodies.

And at their head stood a single fiend.

“By command of the Lord of Heaven…”

His blood-red eyes shone with joy.

What a magnificent day this was. The orthodox Murim would remember it. Everyone would gaze upon Dark Heaven’s flag hanging over the world and tremble with fear.

Quivering with elation, the First Fiend shouted,

“Destroy the Sichuan Tang Clan!”

“As you command!”

Boom. Boom-boom. Boom-boom-boom-boom-boom!

The drums quickened amid fierce battle cries. Three hundred black-clad men charged toward the walls, while dark clouds rolled across the sky and smothered the sunlight that had only just begun to shine.

That was when a powerful shout erupted from atop the walls.

“These villains dare invade our family! Don’t leave a single one alive!”

“Everyone, fire!”

Shhhhhhhk! Thud!

An arrowhead shot with tremendous force pierced someone’s body and buried itself in the ground. Blood mist bloomed, followed by a scream.

“Gaaaaah!”

But there were very few casualties. Most of the black-clad men deflected the arrows with their weapons, while others emerged unharmed thanks to their armor.

“Wh-what?”

“Even the crossbows can’t pierce it? What kind of armor is that…?”

Even crossbow bolts capable of punching through thick iron plates proved useless against the armor.

As the Tang Clan martial artists faltered, a small figure streaked forward at dazzling speed.

Fwoooosh!

“Ha-ha-ha-ha! Excellent! Excellent!”

No one atop the walls knew the First Fiend’s identity. But everyone who heard his crazed laughter felt their hair stand on end.

“The Myriad-Poison Formation! Activate the Myriad-Poison Formation!”

The panicked order rang out, but the First Fiend had already vanished like a ghost and reached the gate.

His face twisting into a fiendish grin, he threw a single punch. Two jiazi[1767] of internal energy spiraled into his fist like a whirlwind.

“Let’s see how Tang Family blood tastes.”

Whoom—Kwahhhhhng!

The battle had begun.

“Hm?”

“What?”

Cheongpung and I looked at each other at the same time. Then, at the same time, we realized we were thinking the same thing.

“Did you hear that?”

“Benefactor, did you hear it?”

The Divine Physician, who was checking the still-unconscious Jeok Cheongang’s pulse, looked at us in confusion.

“What are you talking about?”

[1767] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; two jiazi represent 120 years.

"Just a moment."

I raised a hand to stop the Divine Physician from continuing and quietly focused my mind.

My body might have been in the underground prison, but my senses were another matter. Amplified several times over by the power of my internal energy, my hearing escaped the labyrinthine prison corridors and rose upward, higher and higher.

And then…

Boom.

This time, I heard it clearly.

Cheongpung set down the food he had been holding and spoke.

"Benefactor, could this be…"

"That's right."

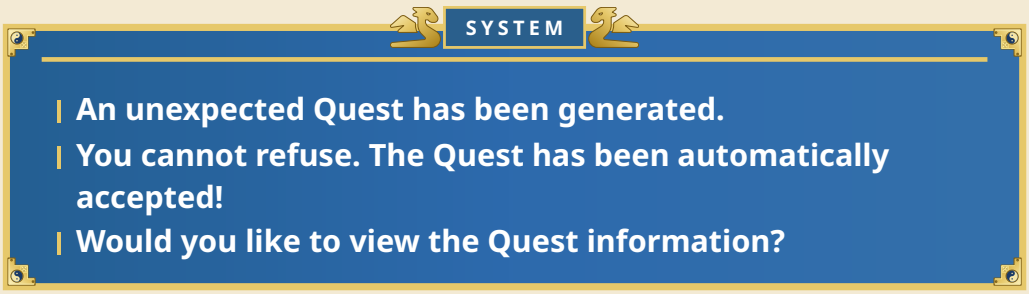
I looked up at the ceiling of the prison and continued,

"It's a drum."

Boom. Boom. Boom.

As though agreeing with me, the drums sounded again at that exact moment.

Ting.



"…"

I stared wordlessly at the holographic window filling my vision.

The sudden drumbeats and an unexpected Quest. Neither could possibly be a good sign.

Shit, I've already got goose bumps all over my arms.

"This is driving me crazy."

But there was no turning back now. The only thing I could do was find out what kind of path lay ahead of me.

View Quest information.

Ting.

A new holographic window appeared with the System's characteristically cheerful notification sound.

Unlike the notification, of course, the contents of the Quest window were anything but cheerful.

SYSTEM

Quest
Uninvited Guest
Dark Heaven's dark clouds have finally spread across Sichuan. The battle has already begun, and the Sichuan Tang Clan is surrounded.
May fortune favor you in battle.
Grade: ???
Limit: ???
Mission: ???
Reward: ???
Failure: Death

I read it exactly three times from beginning to end. Then I thought,

What kind of fucked-up situation is this?

I was so dumbfounded that I could barely speak.

The whole thing was absurd. Enemies had invaded. We were surrounded and couldn't escape. It wished us luck. The end.

Goddamn, it's disgustingly simple.

Grade, limit, mission, reward. Every last one was a question mark.

Well, at least it had made one thing perfectly clear.

If I failed this Quest, I would die.

What a revelation. If we couldn't stop the enemies who had invaded, I would die. Such wonderfully useful information almost made me slap my balls in amazement.

Is this a Quest information window or just a Quest notification window?

Boom. Boom. Boom.

My vision swam. As the drumbeats grew louder and fiercer, cold sweat gathered on my back.

My mind, on the other hand, had gone cold as ice.

I dismissed the Quest window, took a deep breath, and spoke.

"Old Man Dong, we have a problem."

The Divine Physician had learned martial arts, but his realm was far below ours.

Unlike Cheongpung and me, he had not heard the drumbeats. He asked with a puzzled expression,

"A problem? What do you mean?"

"Enemies have invaded."

"Enemies? Here, at the Sichuan Tang Clan?"

"Yes. There's no doubt. We're already surrounded."

The Divine Physician looked as if he could hardly believe it. That was a perfectly normal reaction. What kind of lunatics would attack the Sichuan Tang Clan?

But if those lunatics were Dark Heaven, that changed everything. They were the very people responsible for staining Shaolin Temple with blood.

Still, every second mattered. There was no time for a detailed explanation.

"We don't know what's going to happen, so steel yourself."

"…I understand."

The Divine Physician nodded grimly.

Perhaps because he had traveled throughout the world and experienced countless things, he seemed to accept reality more quickly than expected.

I looked at Jeok Cheongang, who still lay there with his eyes closed.

"How is my Master's condition?"

"As I told you before, his qi has not yet stabilized. If he suffers an external shock in this condition…"

The Divine Physician did not finish, but I had heard enough.

Jeok Cheongang's condition was still unstable. According to the Quest window, Dark Heaven had already surrounded the Sichuan Tang Clan.

What if we broke through their encirclement and escaped?

The thought flashed through my mind, but I quickly shook my head.

Jeok Cheongang's safety was one concern, but our chances of success were slim to begin with. Considering the forces Dark Heaven had deployed against Shaolin Temple, trying to escape might only lead us straight into a deathtrap.

Especially if a monster like the Blood Lord is out there. We have to avoid that at all costs.

After thinking it through, I arrived at a single answer.

I slowly opened my mouth.

"Cheongpung."

Cheongpung answered in a subdued voice.

"Yes, Benefactor."

"Can I ask you for one favor?"

"Anything."

Cheongpung was endlessly innocent and carefree, but every once in a while, he showed a serious side.

And whenever he did, I found him more dependable than anyone else.

That was why I could make this request of him.

"Stay here and protect Old Master—protect my Master. That's my request."

"…!"

"As you heard, we can't get out right now. Someone has to leave and help the Sichuan Tang Clan."

"Benefactor."

"So…"

"Benefactor."

I swallowed the words I had been about to say. Cheongpung was looking at me with clear eyes.

"I'll stay if you tell me to stay, and I'll go if you tell me to go. But, Benefactor…"

His quiet voice reached my ears.

"You have someone you need to protect, don't you?"

"…!"

"When there was someone I had to protect, I was too scared to fight. I couldn't protect the people I cared about. That's why I'm such a fool."

I hadn't known.

I hadn't known Cheongpung carried such thoughts.

Even afterward, he had remained cheerful and talkative, living as though he were the happiest person in the world.

That was how he had always been. It suited him. It was only natural for him.

But it wasn't.

As if recalling what had happened in Henan, Cheongpung turned his gaze toward some distant, dark corner of the underground prison.

Then he turned back to me.

A smile appeared on his lips. The same as always, yet somehow different.

Only then did I understand.

The time had come to make a real decision.

One person stays. One person leaves.

I slowly shifted my gaze.

Cheongpung, still smiling.

The Divine Physician, his face filled with concern.

Someone's screams and shouts, drawing closer by the moment.

And then…

Jeok Cheongang's face beneath the shadows of the flickering torchlight.

The next moment, my lips moved before I knew it.

"Cheongpung. I have a favor to ask."

Cheongpung's gaze met mine.

I pointed toward the ceiling and flashed him a grin.

"Go land one on those sons of bitches and come back."

"Yes, Benefactor!"

His answer was brighter than ever.

Chapter 354

Clang! Krrr-kang!

“They’re vile bastards we could chew to pieces and still not be satisfied! Show no mercy!”

“The Lord of Heaven wills it! Destroy the Tang Clan!”

Sword clashed against sword. Ragged breathing mingled with hoarse cries. The killing intent and stench of blood from hundreds of people locked in battle flooded the air.

Amid the dawn mist, blackened by poison smoke, those intent on killing raised their weapons and charged at one another.

Pfft!

“Gaaah!”

A young man screamed.

Born into a collateral branch of the great Sichuan Tang Clan, he had reached the First Rate realm without much difficulty. His considerable martial talent and composure beyond his years had earned him high expectations from everyone around him.

But now, the young man’s bright future was extinguished by a flash of black Sword Energy.

Fwoooosh! Slash!

The Sword Energy carved diagonally through his upper body.

That was the end.

The black-clad man stared at the young man’s collapsing body, his face pale as blood and entrails spilled out.

The kid was vicious.

The fight had been decided in only three exchanges.

Yet the unknown Tang Clan martial artist had staked his life on leaving them both grievously wounded.

The ox-hair needle that had somehow burrowed beneath the black-clad man’s collarbone was proof.

So this is the Sichuan Tang Clan.

Clicking his tongue, the black-clad man pulled out the needle.

It was so fine that he had to look closely to make it out, and its tip had turned black. There was no question that it had been coated in poison.

“Ghk!”

His vision blurred for an instant. The poison that had entered near his collarbone was rapidly spreading throughout his body.

At this rate, even his Peak-level internal energy could do no more than buy him time.

On a chaotic battlefield like this, being struck by one of the Sichuan Tang Clan's deadliest poisons meant he was as good as dead.

But the black-clad man did not panic.

No—he smiled.

"The Lord of Heaven is… great."

The muffled words slipped between his clenched teeth.

When he opened his mouth for the first time, a small bead lay inside.

An eerie light flowed from the bead and streamed down his throat like a river.

Ssssss.

The change was instantaneous. His blurred vision cleared, and strength and vitality returned to his weakening body.

As every trace of poison vanished from his body, the black-clad man shuddered.

The Lord of Heaven, nobler and greater than any other.

The life force bestowed upon him by his god filled his entire body.

"The Lord of Heaven has descended upon me!"

With a cry of ecstasy, the black-clad man turned in search of another victim.

That was when—

"Wrong. The one descending upon you bastards is Yama.[1768]"

Crack!

A throwing blade flew from somewhere and buried itself between his eyebrows.

The internal energy carried by the blade tore through flesh and bone, reducing his brain to pulp. He died instantly.

Thud. Crash!

The bead that rolled from the dead man's mouth was drawn into someone's hand.

An old man studied it with wizened gray eyes and muttered, "These bastards… They're carrying artifacts."

An ordinary martial artist would have assumed the bead was a poison-warding pearl.

But the old man, Tang Jinhu, was a direct descendant of the Sichuan Tang Clan and a veteran of the Great Faction War. He instinctively realized that this bead was something different from a poison-warding pearl.

What is this?

Poison-warding pearls were normally clear. The more transparent they were, the more effective they were at neutralizing poison—and the more valuable they became.

[1768] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld who judges the dead.

But the bead the black-clad man had possessed shone with an ominous black light, as though it held storm clouds within it.

Even so, it had been powerful enough to neutralize one of the Tang Clan's deadliest poisons.

The greater problem was…

Every last one of them has an artifact of this quality. At this rate, neither our family's poison techniques nor the poison formations we prepared in advance will be of any use.

On top of that, they wore leather armor that ordinary swords and blades could not pierce.

Tang Jinhu finally understood why the Tang Clan drum had sounded.

At this rate, the bloodbath would be even more horrific than the one in the Gyeongwol Year.

"These bastards…"

Crunch.

Tang Jinhu crushed the bead in his hand and thrust out both arms, his face brimming with killing intent.

The silver threads wound around his wrists drank in his internal energy and snapped taut.

The next instant, a dazzling white flash filled the battlefield.

Screeeech—thud-thud-thud!

"Ghk!"

"Gaaah!"

Only a handful of those struck managed even a final scream. Death came equally to First Rate and Peak masters alike.

Raising their weapons to block was useless. The threads Tang Jinhu unleashed lived up to the name Soul-Severing Thread, slicing through everything in their path.

Blades. Bone and flesh. Even the lives of his enemies.

Tang Jinhu felled more than ten black-clad men with a single move, then released an azure dragon's roar.

"Don't retreat! Aim your hidden weapons at their vital points and attack them together!"

"Head Elder! This old man has come as well!"

"Would you look at these fucking bastards! How dare they invade our family? Do you not see the Heaven-Poison Wanderer before you?"

Tang Jinhu was a Supreme Peak master who had retired more than a decade ago, as well as the head of the Council of Elders.

The sight of veteran masters joining the battlefield one after another at precisely that moment brought color back to the faces of the Tang Clan martial artists who had begun to falter.

“G-Grandfather!”

“The Head Elder is here! The Council of Elders has mobilized!”

But their joy lasted only an instant.

Krrr-kang! Slash!

“Gaaah!”

“Tang Hwi!”

“Brat! Is this the time to be looking away?”

Pfft-pfft-pfft!

“Help me… Ghk!”

“Lord of Heaven!”

“The great Lord of Heaven is with us! Kill them all!”

The black-clad men were more skilled than the Sichuan Tang Clan martial artists, while their armor and bizarre poison-warding pearls rendered the Tang Clan’s famed poisons and hidden weapons useless.

A dozen Elders, including Tang Jinhu, and dozens of Peak masters whom the Tang Clan had painstakingly trained fought desperately.

But their limits were clear.

Screeeech—thud!

Tang Jinhu severed the throats of two black-clad men charging at him with the Soul-Severing Thread and ground his teeth.

“Where did these bastards come from…?”

The sight before him was appalling.

The black-clad men swung their weapons while crying out to the Lord of Heaven as if possessed.

Each time they blocked swords and hidden weapons with their armor and pressed onward through the poison smoke, blood sprayed and corpses piled up.

In the vacant eyes of a Tang Clan martial artist whose breath had stopped, red flames that had sprung up somewhere flickered. The hot fire and acrid smoke drove away the poison mist and consumed the fallen corpses.

Tang Jinhu roared, his voice raw enough to spit blood.

“No! You bastards! How dare you—how dare you lay hands on my own flesh and blood!”

Even the mighty forces of the Demonic Cult had suffered more than a thousand casualties to overcome the Tang Clan.

How could a mere three hundred enemies wreak such horrific devastation?

“Ghk! H-Head Elder…”

“Hyung![1769]”

Pfft-pfft-pfft!

Even the Elders who had once roamed the martial world could not escape death.

They had not reached the exalted Supreme Peak realm as Tang Jinhu had, but every one of them was a veteran master who had reached the very edge of Peak.

Yet whenever they cut down one enemy, five more charged in. When they cut down those five, ten more rushed forward.

Among those ten black-clad men who charged forward without regard for their lives, a Peak master was hiding.

Slash. Crash!

After sacrificing dozens of his subordinates to behead another Elder, the black-clad man laughed triumphantly.

“So much for a Tang Clan Elder.”

“You bastard!”

Screeeech! Thud!

Despite Tang Jinhu’s furious efforts, the situation did not improve.

More than a hundred clansmen had already lost their lives, and half the Outer Hall had fallen into enemy hands.

“Huff, huff.”

Worse, his internal energy and stamina were rapidly running dry.

The battle had already reached a point where one aging Supreme Peak master could no longer turn the tide.

A lament slipped from Tang Jinhu’s lips as he realized the truth.

“What are the Family Head and the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders doing?!”

If they were here, things would be different. Tang Sadok, the head of the family and its strongest master, along with the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders.

If they joined the battle, they could turn the tide.

But—

“Heh-heh. They’re probably quite busy by now.”

The sudden voice in his ear made Tang Jinhu’s heart drop.

“Who are you?”

“As for who this old man is… Damn it. I can’t see a thing. Get the hell out of my way.”

Boom!

With a tremendous blast of displaced air, three or four black-clad men were hurled away as bloody pulp.

[1769] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or a close older male.

An old man drenched in blood strode into the newly cleared space and flashed Tang Jinhu a wide grin.

"Much better. Now I can see."

He was short and ugly.

Tang Jinhu's eyes trembled as he stared at him.

"You…"

"Hm? Do you know me?"

"…I never expected the Fiend of Qinghai to still be alive."

First Fiend stared at Tang Jinhu for a moment, then his eyes widened.

"Ah, now I remember. You're that youngster from the Tang Family. So, have you gotten any better at using the Soul-Severing Thread?"

"Good enough to cut off your head."

"I always thought the Sichuan Tang Clan was fairly practical for an orthodox faction. Looking at you, I suppose that isn't entirely true. Not if you still indulge in such foolish fantasies."

"…!"

"Youngster, you still don't understand, do you? Then this old man will tell you himself."

First Fiend cackled.

"You, your Family Head, and those idiots called the Tang Clan's Ten Wonders will all die. Whether they bear the Tang surname or are nothing but dogs, I'll kill and burn every last one of them."

"You—!"

"Don't be too upset. The Lord of Heaven treats all people equally. He has bestowed the same punishment upon the Buddhist nuns and those Daoist bastards. Heh-heh-heh."

Tang Jinhu froze, forgetting even his anger.

Only then did he realize that First Fiend's two younger brothers, who had always followed him like shadows, were nowhere to be seen.

…Emei[1770] and Qingcheng.[1771]

The carnage of corpses and blood had not been limited to the Tang Clan.

The Sichuan Tang Clan, Emei, and Qingcheng.

He could feel the people's screams and deaths.

Today, the three factions that ruled Sichuan would fight for their very survival.

Inside the hellscape those men had painted.

"Even after all these years… You truly are a Fiend."

Tang Jinhu spat out the words.

[1770] Emei is a Buddhist martial sect associated with Mount Emei in Sichuan.

[1771] Qingcheng is a Daoist martial sect associated with Mount Qingcheng in Sichuan.

First Fiend answered with a radiant smile.

“How kind of you. Could there be any greater praise for this old man?”

“I’ll kill you.”

“Your body has grown old, but your dreams remain ambitious.”

First Fiend burst into mad laughter and raised the twin axes in his hands.

“Now, shall we have another taste of blood?”

As if those words were a signal, hundreds of black-clad men who had already occupied the Outer Hall poured forward like a wave.

The surviving Tang Clan martial artists stood in their path, resolved to fight to the death.

“Go! Kill everything you see!”

“Stop them! We must never let them into the Inner Hall!”

Those trying to break through and those trying to stop them.

At the forefront, two men charged straight at each other.

Screeeech!

Tang Jinhu unleashed the Soul-Severing Thread with every ounce of his strength, firm resolve burning in his eyes.

Family Head, please be safe.

Kwahhhhhng!

“Cough!”

Tang Sadok stared at his palm with trembling eyes. Small pieces of his organs lay amid the dark-red blood.

“How… How could this…”

His head slowly rose as the exhausted words left him.

At that very moment, another life was extinguished.

Crunch! Thud!

A headless body toppled like a rotten log.

Considering the fame the man had enjoyed in life, it was a pitifully meaningless death.

“Were they called the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders? They’re more capable than I expected.”

A few steps from the corpse, a middle-aged man wiped the blood spattered across his face and continued.

“Of course, we’ll have to call them something else now. Let me see… Yes. The Tang

Clan's Three Skills[1772] seems appropriate."

"…!"

Tang Sadok stared at the middle-aged man through blurred eyes.

The man had introduced himself as the Western Heaven Demon Lord. This enemy who had killed Tang Sadok's father was overwhelmingly powerful. Neither Tang Sadok's poison arts nor the combined assault of the Tang Clan's Ten Wonders had been of any use.

Is this how it ends?

Tang Sadok still had the strength to fight. So did the other three surviving members of the Tang Clan's Ten Wonders.

But…

How can we possibly stand against that monster?

What raised him from the depths of despair was the mettle he possessed as the Family Head—and the blood of the Tang Family flowing through his veins.

"Not yet. It isn't over yet."

"Why not remain seated? You cannot have much strength left."

"I don't know why, but I know you have no intention of killing this old man."

"…Hm. As I said, the Poison King raised his son well."

"Then kill me."

"That won't do. But I suppose I should wear you down a little more."

The Western Heaven Demon Lord frowned and reached toward Tang Sadok.

That was when—

"Wait! Please, wait!"

"…?"

A young man rushed in with a shout, then let out a sigh of relief.

"Phew. I'm not too late. Thank you for waiting!"

As the Western Heaven Demon Lord stared at Cheongpung, a single thought crossed his mind.

What kind of lunatic is this?

[1772] In Korean, the words rendered as "Wonders" and "Skills" are pronounced alike; he changes both the number and the written title to belittle them.

Chapter 355

“Phew. I’m not too late. Thank you for waiting!”

What kind of lunatic is this?

At the sight of the young man strolling in as casually as if he belonged there, the Western Heaven Demon Lord let out an involuntary, hollow laugh.

I emerge after all this time, and now I’m running into all kinds of strange people.

He considered himself a man who had lived a fairly extraordinary life, but the young man before him easily surpassed anything he had imagined.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord found that rather unfortunate. He had wasted time, and the young man had hastened his own death.

“What’s there to thank me for? Farewell.”

Swish!

Even livestock called for different blades.

If Tang Sadok and the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders were pigs, that brat was an ant.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord did not even feel the need to draw his favored weapon. He flicked a finger toward the young man’s brow, then started to turn his head toward Tang Sadok.

Or rather, he was about to when—

“Whoa. That nearly scared the life out of me.”

“…?”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stared at the young man, eyes widening.

The brat should have been lying dead by now, yet he was looking back at him with an innocent grin.

In the iron pillar exactly half a step to his side was a hole the size of an egg.

Right where the young man’s head had been only a moment before.

…He dodged it? The eighth-stage Ghost Prison Finger?

It should not have happened. It could not have happened.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord wondered if something had gone wrong with his body without his noticing.

Then—

“Stand back.”

Tang Sadok spoke, his face rigid. Pale from his internal injuries, his expression held a trace of dismay.

“This is no place for a greenhorn like you to interfere… Cough!”

“Gasp! Blood! You’re bleeding!”

When Tang Sadok suddenly vomited blood, the young man stepped forward with a worried look.

“Grandpa Tang, are you all right?”

Swish!

In the blink of an eye, the young man flipped through the air as a flash of light sprang from his waist.

Drawing his sword at the same time, he deflected the slash that came flying through the air. Then he panted heavily.

“Huff, huff. That startled me. Why did you do that without saying anything?”

“Ha-ha. Ha-ha-ha!”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord looked from the sword in his right hand to the young man, then burst into hearty laughter.

Though he had not used his full strength, that single exchange had taught him two things.

First, the mysterious young man was not merely a lunatic.

And second—

“You must be the Disciple Sword Saint Mae Jonghak took in during his later years. Your name was… Cheongpung, wasn’t it?”

Cheongpung stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord with round eyes.

“Oh? You know me?”

“How could I not, when the scent of Huashan’s plum blossoms pours from your footwork? It has been a long time since I saw such an exceptional Dark Fragrance Drift.”

“Wow! You know Dark Fragrance Drift! But how do you know my name…?”

“I have many unseen eyes and ears.”

Dark Heaven had spent many years planting spies throughout the world, and Sichuan Province was no exception.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had already known for ten days that Cheongpung was staying at the Tang Clan.

He had not expected them to meet at such a perfect moment.

To have reached this realm at his age… The Sword Saint has raised a monster.

There was a reason he had failed to recognize Cheongpung at first glance.

As the Western Heaven Demon Lord examined Cheongpung from head to toe with a peculiar look in his eyes, Tang Sadok parted his bloodstained lips.

“You vicious bastard. Was attacking our family not enough? Now you mean to harm that boy as well?”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord answered gently.

“No. Not at all.”

“He has nothing to do with our family… What?”

The unexpected answer made Tang Sadok and even the three surviving members of the Tang Clan’s Ten Wonders doubt their ears.

But the Western Heaven Demon Lord, the man at the center of it all, remained impassive.

“I have no intention of taking prey someone else has already marked. Personally, I am not particularly fond of him, but we serve the same master.”

“…What are you talking about?”

“An acquaintance of mine became quite angry recently. It seems the wound to his pride hurt more than losing his arm. He is determined to kill that young man with his own hands.”

Tang Sadok’s expression twisted at the incomprehensible explanation.

Then Cheongpung suddenly spoke.

“The Blood Lord. It’s him.”

“So you do remember him. He’ll be delighted when I tell him.”

“I don’t like him.”

Anyone who knew Cheongpung—especially Jin Taekyung—would have stared at him with his mouth hanging open.

Cheongpung’s nature was as clear as a mountain stream, and he had never once declared that he liked or disliked someone.

Not even those who had approached him with ill intent.

But now, unmistakable hostility had appeared in Cheongpung’s transparent eyes.

“Is he here right now?”

“Unfortunately, he is far away. But he would be very pleased to see you. Ah, and of course…”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord continued smoothly.

“The same goes for the Fire King being treated at the Tang Clan and the young man named Jin Taekyung.”

“…!”

“I told you. I have many eyes and ears.”

A smile formed at the corner of the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s mouth.

“Do not worry too much. I intend to take all three of you alive. Whether my friend the Blood Lord feels the same, however, I cannot say.”

Cheongpung sensed the chilling edge hidden beneath the man’s gentle voice.

Without realizing it, he tightened his grip around his sword hilt. A different tone and voice than usual slipped through his lips.

“It won’t be easy.”

“I wonder if that’s really—”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s voice never finished.

A tremendous boom split the air, and dozens of flashes filled the pavilion reduced to rubble.

Swish, swish-swish-swish!

Tang Sadok and the Tang Clan's Ten Wonders—or rather, the three who should now be called the Tang Clan's Three Skills[1773]—shot toward a single target like arrows, as if they had planned it together.

Dozens of hidden weapons filled the air from every direction, each aimed at a lethal acupoint, while Tang Sadok drew on every last ounce of strength and drove his fist into the Western Heaven Demon Lord's chest.

"You bastard—!"

Kwahhhhhng! Rumble, rumble!

The aftermath was powerful enough to be called an earthquake.

Tang Sadok and the three Tang Clan martial artists had personally experienced the Western Heaven Demon Lord's might.

They had no intention of squandering their one chance. Their final assault, launched by drawing even upon their innate qi, was devastating.

We did it.

Within the cloud of dust so thick he could not see an inch ahead, Tang Sadok smiled brightly despite coughing up blood.

He had realized that the punch he had unleashed with all his strength had crushed the enemy's flesh and bones and pierced through his chest.

This is the Tang Family's revenge.

That was when—

"Did you think this would be enough?"

"…!"

Crack!

A powerful hand closed around Tang Sadok's neck as the calm voice reached him.

As the dust dispersed, he saw one of the Tang Clan's Three Skills dead with a massive hole through his chest. The Western Heaven Demon Lord stood behind the corpse, reaching over its shoulder.

At the Western Heaven Demon Lord's feet, two people who had once possessed human shapes lay shattered across the ground.

How?

That single thought filled Tang Sadok's mind.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord smiled gently as he held the dazed Tang Sadok by the throat. Then he swung the sword in his other hand.

Kwahhhhhng!

A wave of Sword Energy surged outward like a tide.

The thirty blades of Sword Energy flying toward him like flower petals were swallowed by the wave and vanished.

[1773] The Korean titles share the final syllable *gi*; only the number changes from ten to three.

But though the petals disappeared, their fragrance remained.

From the foot of the young man driving into the air at the speed of a flash, the scent of plum blossoms planted by Huashan and brought into bloom by the Sword Saint rose up.

Sssshing!

“The Meteor Chasing the Moon Sword!”

A single sword thrust forward, leaving a pale afterimage.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord let out a brief cry of surprise and brought his sword down.

His sinuous Snake Sword collided with Cheongpung’s plum-blossom-engraved blade.

Kwang! Kwang-kwa-kwa-kwang!

Every clash of the two swords unleashed a deafening boom like an exploding shell.

It did not take long for one side to gain the upper hand.

Swish—bang!

A figure went flying under the force of the impact.

Cheongpung twisted in midair and landed, then stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

“I expected you to be strong, but… you really are.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s martial prowess was extraordinary.

He had seized an overwhelming advantage with only one hand, all while holding Tang Sadok captive.

At Cheongpung’s apparently awed remark, the Western Heaven Demon Lord let out a quiet laugh.

What an impudent brat. He’s hiding quite a bit, too.

Irritated, he briefly considered teaching the brat a lesson himself.

But he had more urgent business.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord clicked his tongue softly, then called in a low voice.

“First Fiend.”

“Yes, Demon Lord.”

Cheongpung was not surprised when First Fiend appeared with a deferential answer. He had sensed the man nearby for the past fifteen minutes.

That meant the attackers had already passed through the Outer Hall and entered the Inner Hall.

The screams were drawing closer.

“Handle that one.”

“You mean the Sword Saint’s successor? I couldn’t be more grateful…”

First Fiend grinned, baring his bloodstained teeth.

He had already claimed nearly a hundred lives, including Tang Jinhu, the Sichuan Tang Clan's Head Elder.

But intoxicated by his first taste of slaughter in so long, he had found it nowhere near enough.

"You know of the Blood Lord's request, I assume."

"Of course. The Sword Saint's youngest Disciple, whom he cherishes like his own child… Heh-heh. This should be fun. I'll leave him barely breathing."

"Keeping him alive would be preferable, but if that proves impossible, you may kill him."

"What?"

"He is dangerous. If you cannot handle him, cut him down before he can grow."

"He's nothing but a greenhorn. I never knew the Demon Lord made jokes. Ha-ha-ha!"

First Fiend's booming laughter rapidly faded.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's gaze had turned cold.

The instant their eyes met, First Fiend felt his heart drop. He hurriedly threw himself facedown on the ground.

"Y-Your orders."

For a moment, he had forgotten what kind of man the Western Heaven Demon Lord was.

He was a man who hid a grim reaper behind a gentle voice, soft manner, and mild expression.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord silently looked down at the sweating First Fiend, then walked past him.

Tang Sadok struggled in pain with the hand around his neck, but the Western Heaven Demon Lord's arm did not move an inch.

"No!"

"Heh-heh. Do you have any idea whose path you're blocking?"

Swish—boom!

Cheongpung charged forward with a desperate shout, and First Fiend moved to intercept him.

Leaving their thunderous clash behind, the Western Heaven Demon Lord continued walking.

The Inner Hall, where craftsmen had forged weapons and children once walked beside martial artists, was now covered in blood and corpses.

Screams and death overflowed from every direction.

And here, only a short distance away, one man watched the destruction of his family with tears streaming down his face.

“Can you feel it? Everything in the Tang Clan is collapsing.”

Tang Sadok’s hollow eyes trembled.

The Tang Clan was not the only thing collapsing. His firm convictions and his heart were crumbling with it.

Then, as tears continued to stream down his face, a quiet voice slipped into his ear.

“Answer me. Where is the Myriad-Poison Ring?”

Chapter 356

The underground prison beneath the Sichuan Tang Clan was dark and damp by nature.

The few torches spaced along the walls gave off less light than fireflies, and the floor was covered in stagnant water of unknown origin that squelched underfoot.

Just like now.

“What a foul smell. Prison or not, how can they lock people up in a place like this?”

“People? This is where they keep beasts. Haven’t you heard that the Sichuan Tang Clan captured fiends from the Great Faction War and subjected them to every torture imaginable? A place like this should hardly surprise you.”

Squelch. Squelch.

There were two voices, but far more sets of footsteps.

I quietly extended my Qi Sense and counted them.

Fifteen.

The two men at the front, presumably the group’s leaders, continued their conversation.

“But where are all the prisoners? There are bars everywhere, but the cells are empty.”

“Everyone imprisoned here is an old monster from the days of the Great Faction War. It wouldn’t be strange if they’d died long ago, especially after being tortured in a place like this.”

“Fair point.”

Their guess was half right and half wrong.

Many of the underground prison’s original residents had indeed passed on to the next world, but more than ten prisoners still remained.

What they had failed to anticipate was that someone unseen had used Pressure-Point Strike on the prisoners and moved them elsewhere.

“I can’t see even a single ant. Wouldn’t it be better to go back upstairs and kill at least one more person?”

“I don’t think we’ve searched even half the place yet.”

“Now that you mention it, what could there possibly be farther in? The others will come through and search every last corner anyway.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. Have you forgotten the Lord of Heaven’s command? What if someone of the Tang bloodline is hiding down here…?”

“No one would be stupid enough to hide in an underground prison. The battle isn’t even over yet, so why would they hide here? I could understand trying to break through the encirclement and escape, but this?”

“Hmm…”

The man let out a low groan, then spoke in a firm voice.

“No. We have been entrusted with the revered Lord of Heaven’s command. The Demon Lord himself is leading by example, yet you intend to shirk your duty?”

“Phew. Damn it.”

“Stop complaining and follow me.”

The Dark Heaven martial artist whose face I did not know had no idea that his fate had been decided by those words.

At his firm response, the other man grumbled.

“You ought to learn some flexibility. Keep living like such a stickler and you’ll die before your time.”

“Don’t say such ill-omened things. I’ll live longer than someone who half-asses everything like you, so worry about yourself.”

“Want to bet?”

“Fine. Why wouldn’t I—”

Long story short, the man who half-assed everything won their bet over who would live longer.

Though only by a fraction of a second.

Shnk!

It was a perfect ambush.

I had concealed my presence and waited in the darkness of the maze-like passage. The instant I drove the dagger in my left hand into one man’s eye, I swung the sword in my right.

I had smeared mud over the blade beforehand to keep it from catching the light. It sheared through flesh and bone.

Slash! Splat!

The two Peak masters died without so much as a scream, collapsing like rotten logs.

Suddenly drenched in blood and filthy water, the black-robed men stared blankly between their leaders’ bodies and me.

“W-What…?”

Thirteen left.

Instead of answering, I swung my sword again. With another grisly sound of parting flesh, a severed head flew into the air.

“Twelve.”

“…!”

A single emotion surfaced in their vacant eyes.

Fear.

"Dead end, huh? The layout down here is pretty fucked up. Apparently, they built it this way in case anyone tried to escape."

"Eek!"

I walked toward the rat trapped at the end of the passage.

Granted, he was rather large for a rat. But despite his size, he had been the first to run. Apparently, he was a coward.

"All right. Time to join your friends in hell."

"F-Fiend!"

"You crazy bastard. When you do it, it's romance, but when I do it, it's adultery?[1774]"

Thud.

The black-robed man dropped to his knees, his face deathly pale. He still had his weapon in hand, but by now he knew perfectly well that it was useless against me.

In the end, he resorted to begging for his life.

"P-Please, spare—"

"F-Fuck off."

Crack.

I snapped the black-robed man's neck without hesitation. His tongue lolled out as his head tilted at an unnatural angle.

Instant death. No question.

"You people always make me do the same job twice. It's not like you were going to get far."

With a sigh, I slung him over my shoulder and retraced my steps. It did not take long to return to the site of my initial ambush.

The man had not made it very far, and over the past ten days I had become familiar with the underground prison's labyrinthine layout.

"Bastards. What the hell are you crawling all the way in here for? Is there something to eat?"

This was the second time the black-robed men had infiltrated the underground prison.

About thirty minutes ago, seven of them had come in. I had killed every last one.

I had helped thin the enemy's ranks for the Sichuan Tang Clan, but I could not feel happy about it. I knew what their presence meant.

The battle is going badly.

The underground prison was located on the outskirts of the Tang Clan's Inner Hall. That meant the Outer Hall, which could be considered the front line, had already been breached.

[1774] This Korean saying calls out a double standard: someone treats the same conduct as acceptable when they do it and wrong when someone else does.

Then what about Cheongpung…?

I shook my head as an ominous thought flashed through my mind.

No way. Even if you dropped Cheongpung into the middle of hell, he'd be the kind of guy who came back alive.

No. He had to be.

Damn it. If only I could at least log out. Then there'd be a little hope.

I had held out some hope, but no such luck.

The System had disabled Logout the instant the Quest began.

Besides, even if Logout suddenly became available, I could not risk returning to the modern world.

The enemy had already broken in twice within the past thirty minutes. If they stormed the place while I was gone, even briefly…

Not only me, but Jeok Cheongang and the Divine Physician would be finished.

I have no choice. I have to stop them here.

They had numbers. I was alone.

I needed to keep making the most of ambushes, as I had just done, while conserving my strength for an emergency.

The whole plan goes to hell if they walk in and find corpses everywhere.

I began moving the scattered bodies one by one.

The place I had chosen as my temporary morgue lay in the deepest, darkest reaches of the underground prison.

Creeeak.

"Long time no see. What's it been, half an hour?"

"…"

"I brought you some new friends so you wouldn't get lonely."

At the center of the prison, where not a single ray of light could reach, an old man festooned with restraints glared at me with blazing eyes.

The Heavenly Power Demon.

"What?"

"…!"

"What are you going to do, glare me to death? If you've got something to say, say it."

"…!!"

"Oh, right. Your pressure points."

I had struck his Paralysis Acupoint and Mute Acupoint, so of course he could not speak.

I walked over and released them. His furious voice immediately burst out.

"What the hell do you think you're doing?"

“Can’t you tell? I’m moving corpses.”

“I can see that! Why the hell are you bringing them here?”

“Keep your voice down. Shout one more time and I might strike a lethal acupoint instead of your Mute Acupoint.”

“…!”

Good. He was quiet now.

Leaving the silenced Heavenly Power Demon behind, I began stacking the bodies I had brought into the prison.

Thump. Rumble-rumble.

“Could you pick up that head over there?”

“…Are you speaking to this old man?”

“Oh, right. You’re in restraints.”

“Huff! Huff!”

The Heavenly Power Demon’s face flushed crimson as he snorted through his nose. Still, he apparently had no desire to get struck in a lethal acupoint, because he just barely swallowed the shout rising in his throat.

“What in the world is wrong with you…?”

“All done. I’m leaving.”

“…!”

“What? Something you want to say?”

The Heavenly Power Demon had refused to utter a word despite my efforts to coax information out of him over the past several days.

A man who had seen enough corpses during the Great Faction War to last a lifetime would not be complaining now without a reason. My suspicion had clearly hit the mark, and he began to stammer.

“N-No. Nothing.”

“Then we’re done.”

“W-Wait. Wait a moment.”

“Last chance. If you have something to say, spit it out.”

The Heavenly Power Demon’s lips worked silently for a moment before he let out a deep sigh.

“Why did you leave only this old man here? Where are the other prisoners?”

“You don’t need to know.”

“Then what are these corpses?”

He tried to sound unconcerned, but the way he studied my expression made it obvious that this was what he had really wanted to ask.

For the past several decades, his only visitor had been Old Man Gung bearing instruments of torture. Now nearly twenty naked corpses had suddenly been piled in front of him. Of course he was curious.

“Has some calamity befallen the Tang Clan?”

“Yeah.”

I added one brief sentence.

“Dark Heaven invaded.”

“…!”

It was the same expression I had seen on his face a few days ago.

Pretending not to notice how the words *Dark Heaven* had made the Heavenly Power Demon freeze, I continued.

“The Outer Hall has already been breached. There’s probably a fierce battle raging in the Inner Hall as we speak. Things are going worse than expected.”

“Who did you say it was?”

“What?”

“You must have interrogated your captives. This old man is asking who leads them.”

“Pretty sharp.”

I had already squeezed information out of one of the seven who first entered the prison.

He had been terrified, but he severed his own heart meridian and killed himself before I could learn much. Still, I had managed to get one man’s title from him.

“The Western Heaven Demon Lord.”

Clatter! Clank!

Just four words.

But their effect on the Heavenly Power Demon was tremendous.

The old man had always hung limply from his restraints, his gaunt body reduced to skin and bone. Now he hauled at the chains as though he might tear himself free at any moment.

He even glared at me with bloodshot eyes.

“Did you just say… the Western Heaven Demon Lord?”

“You know him?”

“I-Is he still alive? Then the Cult Leader! What happened to the Cult Leader?”

What was wrong with this old man all of a sudden?

Caught off guard, I answered.

“…At this hour? He’s probably eating breakfast.”

It was my first time hearing the title Western Heaven Demon Lord, so how would I know what had happened to the Demonic Cult’s Cult Leader? It was not as if the Demonic Cult had an official Twitter account.

“So it has finally come to this. In the end… it has come to this. Ha. Ha-ha-ha!”

After babbling words I could not understand, the Heavenly Power Demon began laughing like a man who had lost his mind.

I stared at him for a moment, then suddenly spoke.

“Spill it. What’s the connection between the Demonic Cult and Dark Heaven? And what kind of fucking bastard is this Western Heaven Demon Lord?”

The laughter echoing through the prison abruptly stopped.

The Heavenly Power Demon’s hollow gaze settled on me.

“He—the man you call the Western Heaven Demon Lord—was one of the four Protectors of the Divine Cult. He served closer to the Cult Leader than anyone… and led him astray.”

“Then…”

“One day, he began calling himself the Western Heaven Demon Lord. That was the beginning of everything. And now it has come to this. In the end, it has come to this. Ha-ha… Hahahaha!”

At that very moment, the Heavenly Power Demon erupted into crazed laughter.

Boom! Rumble-rumble!

A tremendous roar sounded in the distance, and the underground prison shook.

Chapter 357

A serene expression. An unhurried gait. A spotless yellow robe.

He alone stood apart—the only person whom the aura of death filling the Sichuan Tang Clan could touch.

“They’re no more than a handful of men at best. Push them back!”

“Fight to the end! We are the Sichuan Tang Clan!”

“Waaaaah!”

With a tremendous roar that shook the earth, two waves crashed into each other. Screams and battle cries mixed together as a thick mist of blood began to form.

It was a savage battle fought with utter disregard for life. The outcome was decided just as swiftly.

“Surround them! Don’t let a single one survive!”

“Gaaaah!”

The black wave of men dressed in black swallowed the wave of green.

When it passed, all that remained in its wake were green-clad corpses scattered like foam.

Watching it all from more than a thousand feet away, the Western Heaven Demon Lord suddenly spoke.

“It’s over.”

Their resolve to stand and fight without retreating was worthy of respect, but they had been hopelessly outnumbered from the start.

Even the poison and hidden weapons that formed the foundation of the Sichuan Tang Clan had been rendered largely ineffective.

The battle—or rather, the war—belonged to Dark Heaven.

“It seems I won’t be able to keep my promise. My apologies, Family Head Tang.”

The more desperate people became, the more their judgment faltered. Tang Sadok had been no exception.

After extracting the answer he wanted by promising to preserve the Tang Family’s lineage, the Western Heaven Demon Lord had taken a simple and cruel course of action.

Rather than kill Tang Sadok immediately, he had seated him against a tree atop a hill overlooking the Sichuan Tang Clan.

There, Tang Sadok could watch his family perish until his own last breath.

“Everything according to the will of the Lord of Heaven.”

Drip. Drip-drip.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord looked up at the sky as rain began to fall, then turned away.

The mouth of a cave yawned open like a black maw. Beside a fallen brazier lay a hunchbacked old man, dead with his eyes wide open.

What caught the Western Heaven Demon Lord's interest were the wounds carved into the old man's body.

The Black Blood Sword Technique.

The Black Blood Sword Technique was permitted only to Dark Heaven martial artists.

Having recognized the identity of those who had arrived before him, the Western Heaven Demon Lord descended the stone steps leading underground.

Footprints stained with blood and mud stood out clearly upon the stairs. At least twenty of his subordinates had passed this way before him.

And most likely…

They're all dead.

There were tracks leading down, but none coming back up.

The moment he entered the underground prison, suspicion became certainty.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had lived a life steeped in blood. He could feel the lingering heat of battle in the dark corridor and smell the metallic reek of blood beneath the stench.

Who did this?

He studied the fine droplets of blood spattered across the wall.

Skilled. They were cut down before they could put up any real resistance.

With the Sichuan Tang Clan in mortal peril, there was no chance any of its masters would remain here merely to guard outsiders.

If Tang Sadok had told the truth, only three people remained in the underground prison.

The Divine Physician was hardly a fighting force, and Fire King Jeok Cheongang had yet to regain consciousness. That left only one person.

Jin Taekyung, the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord recalled what the Blood Lord had said about Jin Taekyung.

The most arrogant and tenacious young bastard under heaven, with more guts than sense.

For some reason, the Blood Lord had wanted to kill Jin Taekyung even more than the Sword Saint who had cut off his arm or the Fire King.

So he's skilled enough to survive an encounter with the Blood Lord?

But Jin Taekyung would not be so lucky twice.

The Sword Saint was not here, and the Fire King was in no condition to fight.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord intended to capture the rats trapped in the jar and return without difficulty.

Along with the Myriad-Poison Ring in their possession.

Squelch. Squelch.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord strolled onward, then abruptly stopped.

A solid stone wall stretching down from the ceiling blocked his path.

“Well, now. They certainly made this place complicated.”

He regarded the wall for a moment, then closed his hand into a fist. Dark-red mist coiled around his arm and enveloped it.

Goooooooong.

Everything happened in an instant.

The manifestation of qi. Its compression. Its explosion.

Nothing could stand in the path of his Fist Force.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Walls shattered and collapsed. The entire prison shook.

The immense concentration of qi shot forward in a straight line, punching through dozens of walls. Stalactites rained from the ceiling like hail, and a dense cloud of dust billowed into the air.

Much better.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord surveyed the path he had created, then spoke.

“Why don’t you come out now?”

His only answer was a piercing shriek through the air.

Whoosh!

The dust cloud split apart. The Western Heaven Demon Lord plucked the dagger flying toward his throat from the air and smiled.

“Are you Jin Taekyung?”

“You already know. Why ask?”

Step. Step.

A tall young man—Jin Taekyung—emerged from the cloud of dust and stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord with an impassive gaze.

I tried to look unfazed.

Half of any fight was momentum. You couldn’t let your guard down because your opponent looked weaker, and you couldn’t let yourself be intimidated because he looked stronger.

Especially when you were facing the real deal.

What kind of monster is this guy?

I stared at the middle-aged man before me, inwardly clicking my tongue.

If Moses had parted the sea with his staff, this man had carved a new path through the underground prison with a single punch.

And that wasn't all. He stood there with a faint smile, the very picture of tranquility.

Even the air around him smells different.

The Blood Lord had been openly insane. This middle-aged man, on the other hand, was dangerous simply by existing.

Their martial arts might have been comparable in strength, but they were completely different in nature.

"I've heard a great deal about you. You're an amusing young man, just as I was told."

I lowered White Flame's spearhead at an angle.

"I'm pretty entertaining myself."

"I also heard you lack manners."

"You've got the wrong man. My nickname is Mr. Manners."

"Well, I would have to spend more time with you to know for certain. But according to an acquaintance of mine, it's true."

"You don't look like you have any friends. Who's the acquaintance?"

The smile on the middle-aged man's lips deepened.

"The Blood Lord."

"…!"

"He's very eager to see you."

"I never want to see that fucking bastard again."

"That young man Cheongpung said the same thing. In a different tone, of course."

This bastard has already met Cheongpung.

And yet he was here…

I felt my face stiffen despite myself.

"You, by any chance…"

The middle-aged man smiled and waved a hand.

"There's no need to worry. I won't kill you. I intend to take you, Cheongpung, and the Fire King back alive."

I asked with a dumbfounded expression.

"Take us?"

"I told you. The Blood Lord wants to see you. So you'll be safe, at least until then."

"…"

"Of course, what happens afterward will be up to the Blood Lord."

The middle-aged man had given me two pieces of good news and one piece of bad news.

The good news was that Cheongpung was alive and the Blood Lord wasn't here. The bad news was that if I lost this fight, we'd all be attending a group get-together with him.

Of course, the chances of us having a drink over grilled intestines before parting ways were close to zero.

The odds that I'll become the grilled intestines instead are probably around fifty percent.

The other fifty percent was the chance I'd end up as grilled tripe.

Damn it. Just thinking about it was making my mouth water.

I swallowed dryly and looked the middle-aged man up and down.

A man who could call the Blood Lord, presumably one of Dark Heaven's highest-ranking figures, an acquaintance. A man who could unleash that much destructive power with a single punch.

A title came to mind.

"You're the Western Heaven Demon Lord, aren't you?"

"Ah, come to think of it, I haven't introduced myself yet. It's a pleasure to meet you."

Pleasure, my ass.

I stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord's two perfectly functional arms and muttered.

"I heard you only had one arm."

"That was true until ten days ago."

"What?"

"I had another attached. It wasn't originally mine, so it still doesn't move quite as well as I'd like. If you intend to try something, aim for my left arm."

"…!"

What the hell was this guy?

Even if some kind of suturing operation was possible, he had replaced an arm as if it were a computer component.

Aside from the subtle difference in skin tone, it moved perfectly naturally.

Is that even possible? And in only ten days?

I couldn't make any sense of it, but I had to set my shock and questions aside for now.

His last remark bothered me even more.

He even told me his weakness.

There could only be one reason for something that absurd.

It was the kind of arrogance only someone certain of his overwhelming strength could display.

And the Western Heaven Demon Lord was strong enough to make arrogance look like composure.

“Damn it.”

I drew a deep breath and fixed him with a cold, level stare.

“Can’t you just pretend you came to visit a patient and turn around?”

“That would be difficult. Setting you people aside, there’s something I have to take with me.”

“Something?”

Instead of answering, the Western Heaven Demon Lord posed a question of his own.

“This old man will ask you this time. Will you surrender? Peacefully.”

“Could you kill yourself for me? Peacefully.”

“Then there’s only one answer.”

Roughly a hundred yards separated us.

The instant our gazes collided across that distance—

Whoosh! Swish!

We both reached out at the same time.

No. When it came to launching our attacks, at least, I was faster.

The only problem was that the Finger Qi the Western Heaven Demon Lord fired reached its target one step before my dagger did.

Striking second, hitting first.

A red warning light flashed in my head. At the same time, my sharpened senses took in everything around me.

The Finger Qi was formless and invisible, yet I could clearly feel its approach. It was a new sense I had acquired while fighting Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

Now!

I twisted my head and shot forward. Something faster than a bullet grazed my ear.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord watched me with open surprise.

“To evade a Ghost Prison Finger at eighty percent power… You certainly have a talent for surprising people as well—”

“Yeah, Ghost Prison Finger.”

Whoosh!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s voice cut off.

Within that slowed instant, his widening pupils reflected me closing in right before his eyes.

My speed lay beyond anything he had imagined—far beyond the limits of a Peak master.

Stamina, Strength, Agility. And the Flamefire Path.

I poured everything into a single step. I erased the distance and tore through the air.

The fire dragon crouched within my qi sea spread its wings and soared. White Flame's transparent spearhead became the dragon's claw, plunging toward my enemy.

Heavenly Strike.

Kraaaaaash!

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

It was a tremendous reverberation.

As if to attest to the ferocity of the fighting, the corpses of enemies and allies piled together in tangled heaps collapsed.

The pavilion shook as though struck by an earthquake. Even those swinging weapons at one another staggered as they momentarily lost their balance.

"An earthquake! It's an earthquake!"

"Damn it, why now…?"

An earthquake was a calamity no human strength could stop.

The tremor lasted only a moment, but it was enough to fill everyone with fear.

Everyone except the two men facing each other in the ruined Family Head's Hall of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

"Ha-ha-ha-ha-ha!"

The old man, the First Fiend, threw back his head and roared with laughter, then turned toward Cheongpung.

"You felt that just now, didn't you?"

Cheongpung nodded, looking dazed.

"Yes."

Of course he had. The tremor had been an immense wave of qi, powerful enough to be felt from hundreds of yards away.

The First Fiend continued with a sneer.

"It seems the Demon Lord has finally made up his mind. Heh-heh."

"I know. It's really amazing."

"He has finally cast aside his last shred of mercy and embraced killing intent. Neither the Fire King nor that disciple of his will survive. Do you understand what that means?"

"Yes. My Benefactor really is amazing."

“Now that we no longer need to worry about the Blood Lord’s feelings, even I won’t show you any mercy from here on—what?”

The First Fiend paused and frowned.

He couldn’t begin to understand what the greenhorn before him had just said.

“Your Benefactor? You mean the Fire King’s disciple?”

But Cheongpung’s next words were not directed at the First Fiend.

In fact, none of his answers had been directed at him from the start.

A quiet murmur slipped from Cheongpung’s lips.

“At first, I thought I was far ahead of him. But before I knew it, he’d already come this far…”

Cheongpung gazed toward the distant source of the tremor, his eyes shining with joy and ruefulness.

No one else in the Sichuan Tang Clan could have guessed the truth—not even the First Fiend standing before him.

But Cheongpung knew.

“There’s no doubt. It’s my Benefactor.”

Cheongpung had been happy on Huashan, but he had also been lonely.

The beautiful scenery, the animals he could play with, and even the grandfather he revered more than anyone else could not fill a certain emptiness within him.

“There are many young prodigies your age in the Murim. The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes are the best among them.”

“Hmm. Then are the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes stronger than me?”

“Huh? What kind of question is that? Of course you, Pung, are—”

“Grandpa?”

“Ahem. Of course you’re still lacking, Pung.”

“Gasp! Really?”

“O-Of course! The world is vast, and there are many masters. So you’ll have to keep working hard at your martial arts from now on, right?”

“Yeees…”

From the single thoughtless remark his grandfather had let slip, Cheongpung felt the unfamiliar emotion in one corner of his heart grow stronger.

Only later did he learn its name.

Competitive pride.

Which of us is stronger?

He wanted to find out. He wanted to pit his martial arts against theirs and spend time with them.

And so Cheongpung left Huashan and ventured into the world. Then, on a sunny winter day, he met him.

“If it wouldn’t be too much trouble, may I have one candied hawthorn skewer?”[1775]

“…Mujin. Give him one.”

That was Cheongpung’s first meeting with Jin Taekyung.

His Benefactor in name, his friend in truth—and now, his one and only true rival.

A gentle smile touched Cheongpung’s lips.

“I know. My Benefactor feels the same way I do.”

“…!”

Flames rose in the First Fiend’s eyes as he watched this.

This greenhorn would have died long ago if not for the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s orders, yet he dared to ignore him. That alone had sealed his fate.

“You little bastard…”

The First Fiend raised his twin axes, their blades caked with scraps of human flesh.

Then he saw what was happening before him and froze like a statue.

Swooshhh.

The wind was blowing.

A scarlet wind of qi flowed from Cheongpung’s body, slid down his wrist, and streamed into his sword.

It passed over the plum blossom engraved upon the hilt, coiled around the blade, and finally bloomed into a single crimson plum blossom.

Crackle-crackle-crackle!

A halo of light, more brilliant and destructive than anything else.

A dazed voice escaped between the First Fiend’s lips as he stared at the unbelievable sight.

“…Sword Force.”

The product of great martial artists. Proof that its wielder had reached the exalted realm known as Supreme Peak.

Yet the twenty-three-year-old young man’s face wore an innocent smile wholly unsuited to a great martial artist.

“So, shall we begin?”

[1775] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional snack made by coating skewered hawthorn fruit in hardened sugar.

Chapter 358

Kraaaaaash!

A spearhead wreathed in blue flame plunged toward the crown of a man's head.

It was the claw of a fire dragon descending from the heavens—a force of destruction that could erase anything in its path.

This is…

In a moment split into ever-smaller fragments, the Western Heaven Demon Lord thought,

I can't evade it.

This was no strike he could avoid by retreating a few steps.

Then what could he do? Before he could even form the question, the body that had survived countless life-and-death duels was already moving.

Whoosh!

Dark-red Sword Force surged from his waist and collided with the blue flames.

Boom!

A tremendous roar erupted, and a shock wave swept through my entire body. My ears went numb, and the breath caught in my throat.

Sword and spear collided in a burst of dark-red light. The next instant, I went flying as though someone had yanked me backward.

Bang! Bang! KABOOM!

The thick wall of sedimentary rock crumbled like castella[1776] the moment my back struck it.

I knocked away a stalactite falling toward my eyes and twisted around in midair.

The instant my feet hit the ground, they plowed furrows through the solid stone floor.

Krrrrrk!

Damn it. I must have flown at least thirty feet.

I tore off my leather shoes, their soles completely gone, tossed them aside, and glared at the bastard in the distance.

"Fucking bastard. You're pretty good, huh?"

"…"

Even through the thick cloud of dust, I could see the Western Heaven Demon Lord's stiff expression.

[1776] Castella is a soft sponge cake of Japanese origin, also popular in Korea.

He silently looked down at the sword blade broken clean in half and his blood-soaked grip before opening his mouth.

“That spear is a divine weapon.”

“Divine? That’s a bit much.”

“What martial art was that?”

I answered without hesitation.

“Get Hit and Fucking Die Technique.”

“I’m beginning to understand why the Blood Lord called you arrogant. And… why he wanted to kill you so badly.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s gaze swept over me.

“You’re dangerous.”

“I am kind of dangerous. Maybe that’s why all the women avoid me.”

“Cheongpung is certainly remarkable, reaching Supreme Peak at such a young age, but even he cannot compare to you. To be honest, you have far exceeded my expectations. Despite being only at Peak, you managed to wound me.”

I wasn’t surprised. I had already sensed that Cheongpung had broken through the wall and reached Supreme Peak.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s accurate assessment of my martial arts realm followed the same logic.

“Was that a compliment?”

“Of course. But do not be too pleased. I do not like people who exceed my expectations.”

Speaking in a low voice, the Western Heaven Demon Lord clenched and unclenched his bloodied palm. Sticky blood dripped down, wetting the rocks and sand.

“My execution of Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties[1777] was flawless. Yet I still failed to redirect your strike completely. A strike from a green young man who has not even advanced beyond Peak.”

Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties[1778]—the martial principle of controlling a thousand catties with only four ounces.

And just as he said, the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s use of Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties[1779] had been flawless. Even after being caught off guard, his attempt to calmly and precisely redirect Heavenly Strike had been impressive enough to earn my secret admiration.

But if there was one thing he had failed to anticipate…

[1777] The name uses traditional Chinese weight units: a *liang*, rendered here as “ounce,” is 50 g (1.76 oz) in modern usage, while a *jin*, or catty, is 500 g (1.10 lb). Historical weights varied.

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“I’m a little stronger than I look.”

He wasn’t facing an ordinary Peak master.

A Third Rate could not contend with a Second Rate, and a Second Rate could only kneel before a First Rate.

The higher the realm, the wider the gulf and the more overwhelming the difference in strength. That was common sense in this world—the common sense of the Murim.

But I defied common sense.

“Call me a physical Supreme Peak master.”

“A physical Supreme Peak master. I have no idea what that means, but if you say so, then so be it. Understood.”

I stared at the nodding Western Heaven Demon Lord in disbelief.

“…What exactly do you understand?”

“Live long enough and you experience all manner of things. Compared to the supernatural powers I know of, what you’ve shown is merely a drop in the bucket.”

With a faint smile, the Western Heaven Demon Lord raised one arm.

The movement was so natural that it was hard to believe he had been one-armed until only ten days ago.

That arm had to be one of the supernatural powers he was talking about.

“Everything shall unfold according to the will of the most exalted Lord of Heaven. Why not abandon your futile hopes and surrender?”

“Surrender?”

“If you do, I will personally petition the Lord of Heaven to put your talents to good use. Even the Blood Lord will not dare touch you.”

“Wow. You’ve got it all planned out.”

“May I take that as your consent?”

“Hmm, wait a second. I just thought of something better.”

I slowly walked toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord as I continued.

“Stories like this always end with good triumphing over evil anyway. So stop screwing around in Dark Heaven or Cheonggyecheon[1780] or whatever and come over to the orthodox faction. I’ll put in a good word with Grandpa Sword Saint and get you an easy job.”

“Heh. Well, this is something.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stepped forward with a faint smile.

“What a pity. Don’t regret this when you meet the Blood Lord.”

[1780] Cheonggyecheon is a stream in central Seoul. Its name sounds similar to Dark Heaven in Korean.

"Every bastard who's said that to me is kneeling with his head planted before Yama[1781] by now."

"Perhaps it's your youth, but you're far too hot-blooded. If you expect the same stroke of luck you enjoyed at the start, forget it. I know that strike was your full strength."

"That's the best bullshit I've heard all year. Have you been taking bullshit lessons from the yellow dog next door?"

I answered casually, but unfortunately, the Western Heaven Demon Lord was right.

A surprise attack had to end everything in one strike. Either cripple the opponent or kill them.

Breaking his weapon and tearing open his hand wasn't enough.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was a master far above me. Showing him my full strength without inflicting any significant injury had been a painful mistake.

Should I have used One Annihilation from the start?

What would have happened if I'd gone all in from the beginning?

I cast the thought aside. Even if I could return to that moment, I probably still wouldn't be able to stake everything on one move.

I had to avoid gambles that left only total victory or utter ruin—especially when lives other than my own hung in the balance.

Besides… I haven't played all my cards yet.

Step. Step.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord and I. He and I. We slowly approached each other.

Unlike our first clash, neither of us launched Finger Qi or daggers.

We measured the distance, watched each other's hands and feet, and waited for the right moment.

A moment exactly like this one.

Snap!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord moved first.

He erased thirty feet in a single step, his hand blurring. Ink-black Sword Force burned along his crooked, serpentine Snake Sword.

Avoid a direct clash at all costs.

If there was one gap even the System couldn't bridge, it was enlightenment.

The difference between someone who had attained the insight required to reach Supreme Peak and someone who had not was as vast as heaven and earth.

No matter how great my strength was, if I repeatedly clashed with Sword Force, I would inevitably suffer internal injuries.

[1781] Yama is the Buddhist ruler and judge of the dead.

Whoosh! Boom!

The Sword Force split the ground, blasting out a crater that looked like something from a movie. If I hadn't barely dodged the strike, it would have cut me in half.

I retreated and flicked my hand.

Inventory open. Summon.

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

I had never formally learned the art of throwing blades, but with enough force and speed behind them, the daggers were deadly in their own right.

Not that it mattered against the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Slice!

A single horizontal line flashed through the air.

Ink-black Sword Energy shot from his blade, slicing through the daggers and flying straight at me.

I tilted my head, and searing heat and Sword Energy grazed past me.

Boom!

Ignoring the roar and tremor behind me, I planted my foot.

Grind. Crack!

The solid stone floor split like a spiderweb. The next instant, I shot forward like a streak of light.

I moved with enough speed to rival a Supreme Peak movement technique—perhaps even surpass one.

"As expected!"

With a short exclamation, the Western Heaven Demon Lord brought his sword down.

Ink-black Sword Force, so dark that it dimmed the very air around it, swept across my body.

It would have cut me apart, if not for the thought that had flashed through my mind a fraction of an instant earlier.

Thirty points each into Agility and Strength.

Swoosh.

The change came with dazzling speed. My whole body grew lighter, while my muscles gained density and elasticity, squeezing out every last bit of strength.

As I stepped upon the wind, the ink-black Sword Force sliced through empty air.

Kraaaaaash!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes flew wide.

It was already too late for him to pull back his sword. He thrust out his other hand, trying to seize the spear hurtling toward his chest.

His reflexes were astonishing.

Just as astonishing was the fact that my prediction had been exactly right.

Inventory open. Store.

Whoosh!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's Force-wreathed hand swept through empty air.

The spear that had seemed certain to fall into his grasp—White Flame—was now safely tucked away somewhere in my inventory.

This was the moment I had been waiting for.

Flame Divine Palm.

My right hand, wreathed in blue flames, slammed into the Western Heaven Demon Lord's abdomen.

Boom!

His body lifted slightly into the air amid the tremendous heat. At that exact moment, I drove my waiting left fist forward.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Crack!

The strike that had brought down a cliff buried itself in the Western Heaven Demon Lord's side.

The impact ran back through my fingertips. His body flew like a cannonball and smashed into the wall.

Bang! KRA-KA-BOOM!

The entire underground prison shuddered. At the same time, unbearable weakness and hunger washed over me.

I had poured everything I had into every movement of that exchange. No wonder ragged breaths spilled from my lips.

"Whew."

Rumble.

I steadied my breathing and slowly walked forward through the stones raining down around me.

Driven deep into the solid rock, the Western Heaven Demon Lord stared at me with unfocused eyes.

"I was definitely trying to catch the spear… How did you…"

"It's probably something like those supernatural powers you believe in."

"Cough. I see. Then is that also how you suddenly became faster?"

"Yeah. A few perfectly good lives were wasted because of you. They were bastards who deserved to die anyway, though."

"What do you mean?"

"This is an underground prison. Haven't you noticed anything strange?"

After a brief silence, the Western Heaven Demon Lord answered.

"…There are no prisoners."

"Correct."

"How did you do it? Did you perhaps use the Essence-Siphoning Great Technique on them?"

"You could say that, in a way."

The difference was that the Essence-Siphoning Great Technique absorbed an opponent's qi, while I sucked up EXP.

Thanks to those guys, I earned sixty points. It was a stroke of genius.

Instead of destroying the prisoners' dantians, the Sichuan Tang Clan had chosen to suppress their internal energy and shackle them.

That way, they could live longer. That way, the clan could make them taste hell through prolonged torture.

Thanks to that, the dozen or so prisoners other than the Heavenly Power Demon had become nourishment for me.

"Cough. The Essence-Siphoning Great Technique. I see. So that was it."

"Are you satisfied now?"

"If I ask, will you answer?"

"Yeah. So…"

I looked down at the Western Heaven Demon Lord as he weakly nodded.

"Drop the lousy act and get up. And enough with the coughing when you're not even bringing up blood."

"Well, this is something."

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes, which had seemed ready to go out at any moment, curved into crescents.

"Apparently, I'm really no good at this sort of thing."

"…Haa."

Fucking bastard.

Chapter 359

Rustle.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord brushed the bits of stone from his body, then rolled his neck from side to side. His brow furrowed as his bones ground against one another.

“Your fists pack quite a punch. Without my Body-Protecting Qi, I might have been seriously injured.”

Quite a punch, my ass.

I let out a deep sigh as I watched him get up as though nothing had happened after taking both my full-powered Flame Divine Palm and Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

“Forget the Body-Protecting Qi. Isn’t it cheating for someone like you to equip gear too?”

“Gear? What is that?”

I pointed at the black-scaled armor visible through the tears in his yellow robe.

“That thing you’re wearing underneath, you bastard.”

“Ah. You mean the Black Dragon Armor.”

“The Black Dragon Armor?”

Now that was one hell of a cool name.

I didn’t know exactly what the Black Dragon Armor was, but its defensive capabilities were so impressive that even calling it a divine weapon didn’t seem like enough.

It had blocked two full-powered attacks, yet all it had lost were a few scales.

With that level of defense, fists and palms won’t cut it.

The armor worn by Dark Heaven’s ordinary martial artists had been formidable too, but it was nothing compared to the Black Dragon Armor.

An eye for an eye. A tooth for a tooth. A divine weapon for a divine weapon.

As long as he had the Black Dragon Armor, I needed White Flame to inflict a fatal wound on him.

Unless…

My gaze probed him for another opening. The Western Heaven Demon Lord smiled faintly.

“The more I see of you, the more interesting you become. Your strange techniques are one thing, but I like your refusal to back down.”

“So? Want to date?”

“I must politely decline. I already have a lover I’ve been with for many years.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord gently stroked his sword's winding blade. Ink-black Sword Force rose from the clean break where half the blade had snapped off.

"I've seen all your cards. Now it's my turn."

With that quiet murmur, the Western Heaven Demon Lord stepped forward. A suffocating aura rippled behind him like wings.

Only then did I realize it.

His martial arts had reached a realm far beyond what I'd imagined.

"…Damn it."

Deng.

I could almost hear a bell ringing somewhere to announce the start of round two.

But this wasn't a boxing match that ended after twelve rounds. There were no spectators to cheer or groan, no staff to throw in the towel.

This match would end only when one of us staked his life—nothing less.

Inventory open. Summon.

The cold spear shaft settled into my grip. I drew a deep breath and leveled the spearhead at the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

"Come at me."

He didn't hesitate.

Snap!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord extended one foot.

Shifting Form and Position.

His vanished figure reappeared in midair above my head.

Every hair on my body stood on end as I leaned backward.

Saaak! Boom!

His heel missed the bridge of my nose by a hair and slammed into the ground. The floor caved in, sending fragments of stone flying in every direction.

Blood trickled from the bridge of my nose where the wind pressure had sliced it, but I wasn't given even a moment to wipe it away.

Shh-shh-shh-shhk!

Ink-black Sword Energy rained down from every direction, slashing and sweeping toward my waist, chest, and stomach without distinction.

They were attacks I could never have dodged in the past.

But not anymore.

I can see them.

In the slowed world, I sensed the Sword Energy hurtling toward me.

I could picture where that destructive energy was headed and how I needed to move to evade it.

My body was already moving ahead of my thoughts.

Kra-kra-kra-kaboom!

I dodged some attacks and knocked others aside with my spear. Thick clouds of dust billowed into the air, and craters like something out of a war movie pockmarked the ground.

And then…

Whooong!

Ink-black Sword Force gleaming with a murky light burst through the dust cloud. His gaze calm and steady, the Western Heaven Demon Lord brought his sword down in a diagonal slash.

I had no way of knowing what martial art or form he was using.

But I knew one thing.

If I backed down here, all that awaited me was death.

I have to strike back.

I needed power strong enough to stand against Sword Force. This was the moment to use the best move I had.

The answer had been there from the beginning.

One Annihilation.

Grind.

Every muscle in my body drew taut like a bowstring. My foot shot forward first, and my waist, bent as far back as it could go, snapped forward. The rotational force flowed through my shoulder and arm and poured into the spearhead.

Kraaaaaash!

It was a concentration of energy far too massive to be called mere Spear Energy.

The spearhead surged forward, wreathed in blue flames. It burned through the air and devoured the dust cloud as it hurtled toward a single man.

"…!"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes widened. At the same time, his blade trembled, and an even greater mass of Sword Force erupted from it.

The next instant, blue flame and black darkness collided.

KABOOOOOM!

A roar unlike anything I had ever heard erupted as everything within a radius of over a hundred feet shattered and exploded.

Part of the ceiling collapsed under the impact, and the incredibly solid rock was pulverized into drifting dust.

Amid it all, one man remained standing.

"Damn it."

Even my full-powered One Annihilation hadn't worked.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord shook his head at my dejected expression. Blood ran down from his shoulder. That was all One Annihilation had left behind.

"There's no need to be disappointed. It was a sufficiently powerful form. For a moment, it even sent a chill through my heart."

"Let me ask you one thing."

"Anything."

"If I hadn't wasted my strength earlier and had opened with that strike… could I have killed you?"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord considered it carefully before answering.

"I believe you could have taken one of my arms. Perhaps even more than that. But you would have been the one to die."

"Damn it. I knew it."

"I think it's time to end this."

Whoooooosh.

It didn't even surprise me anymore. Sword Force surged like water from an inexhaustible spring and lashed toward me like a whip.

I gritted my teeth as the drain on my internal energy left me weak to the point of collapse.

"It's… not over yet."

I drew up every last bit of internal energy I had and unleashed the Fire Dragon Divine Spear.

The blue flames were visibly smaller than before. They shot toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord's exposed throat.

Screeeeeech!

The next instant, I met his unwavering gaze and realized it.

He read me.

By the time the realization flashed through my mind, it was already too late. The Sword Force that had seemed poised to cut me down abruptly changed course in midair and struck the spearhead.

Boom!

A roar like the sky splitting apart rang out. I clenched my teeth and held on to the spear shaft as it bucked violently in my hands.

My ankles were already buried deep in the ground when the Sword Force swept toward me.

Shh-shh-shh-shh-shhk!

Above, below, left, and right.

Terrifying energy hurtled in from thirty-six directions around me.

Every nerve in my body screamed as I swung my spear like a madman.

Boom! Kra-kra-kra-kaboom!

My body staggered and my breath caught with every strike I deflected.

This wasn't a matter of speed or strength.

It was martial arts—and internal energy.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's martial arts occupied a distant realm beyond my reach, and the terrifying internal energy transmitted through my spear battered me from within.

What the hell…!

Blood sprayed between my clenched teeth. My torn hands had been covered in blood for some time already.

I squeezed out every last ounce of strength and swung my spear at the ink-black Sword Force cleaving toward my chest.

The second form of the Fire Dragon Divine Spear.

Heavenly Strike.

Screeeeeech! Boom!

But unlike before, the fire dragon's claw was pitifully weak, while the Western Heaven Demon Lord's ink-black Sword Force hadn't lost even a fraction of its power.

Krrrrk!

I was driven backward, carving a long furrow through the ground.

Before me, the underground prison shook as though caught in an earthquake, thick clouds of dust filling the air.

He's gone.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was nowhere to be seen. Not ahead of me, to either side, or above.

That left only one possibility.

I spun around and unleashed a palm strike.

Bang! Boom!

Two sounds rang out at once.

The heat of the Flame Divine Palm burned through the air, while the Western Heaven Demon Lord's palm struck my chest.

My vision went white. Then came the agony of my heart meridian tearing apart strand by strand. I swallowed the blood surging up my throat and regained control of my body as I was hurled backward.

"That was remarkable. I mean it."

"…!"

It was pure instinct.

At the quiet voice that suddenly came from beside me, my arm moved on its own. The hand blade shooting toward the back of my neck struck my forearm instead.

Crack!

Pain flooded through me with the sound of bone shifting out of place. Then the Western Heaven Demon Lord's foot lashed out like a whip and buried itself in my side.

Thud! Boom!

I smashed through the rock and became embedded in the wall. The Western Heaven Demon Lord slowly walked toward me.

Admiration and delight filled his eyes.

"Incredible. Truly incredible. Do you know what you just did?"

I spat out a mouthful of bloody phlegm.

"No, you fucking bastard."

"You should be proud. You lasted more than three hundred moves against me while I was fighting at full strength."

"Three hundred moves. I'm crying tears of joy."

"You don't seem particularly happy, so let me put it another way. What if I told you the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun and her Elders lasted more than five hundred moves?"

"Nope. Still not happy."

"Why not?"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord looked genuinely baffled. I tossed him a curt answer.

"They died anyway."

Three hundred moves, five hundred moves, a thousand moves—it didn't matter. If you lost the fight, all that awaited the loser was death.

The Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun and the Poison King had been no exception.

And…

Neither was I, probably.

"Cough."

Blood seeped between my parted lips.

I wanted to get up as casually as the Western Heaven Demon Lord had earlier, but my body was in no condition for that.

Internal injuries aside, my left arm is fractured, and I think I've cracked some bones in my chest.

I'd really taken one hell of a beating. No wonder breathing had been difficult for a while now.

Panting, I planted White Flame like a cane and dragged myself upright.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes lit up.

"Do you still have something left to show me?"

"Of course."

“That must also be the power of those supernatural powers. Show me. Quickly! Quickly!”

“I was planning to.”

I leveled my spear at the Western Heaven Demon Lord, who was practically bouncing with excitement like a child.

And that was all I did.

“…?”

“What are you waiting for? Come at me.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stared at me in confusion.

“What did you just do?”

“I’m showing you. The supernatural powers you wanted to see.”

“What?”

“I’m good with my body, but hopeless with my head. I’m such a dumbass that I even failed the Level Eight Hanja exam.[1782] Then I came across the term ‘supernatural powers’ in a martial-arts novel. I didn’t know what it meant, so I looked it up.”

Even if I explained it like this, he probably wouldn’t understand half of what I was saying.

My vision wavered. Every time I exhaled, my lungs prickled as though they were being stabbed with needles, and the spear shaft that had always felt light now seemed like a boulder weighing ten thousand geun.[1783]

Even so…

“‘Supernatural powers.‘ Mysterious beings or phenomena that are difficult to explain through reason. That’s what it meant.”

I neither staggered nor collapsed. I simply stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord and continued speaking slowly.

“What’s so special about supernatural powers? A bastard who keeps fighting even after he’s been reduced to this—that’s supernatural powers.”

Remaining Stat Points? None.

Physical condition? It was a miracle I could still stand.

Now that everything had flown out like the contents of Pandora’s box, the one thing left inside me wasn’t hope.

Sheer grit.

Hope could make someone rise again, but it could also make them weak.

But as long as that grit remained—as long as I still possessed the will to fight to the bitter end—I wouldn’t fall.

[1782] Hanja are Chinese characters used in Korean writing; Level Eight is a basic certification level, making failing the exam a mark of being exceptionally bad at them.

[1783] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun would be 6,000 kg (about 13,200 lb); the weight is used here as an exaggeration.

No.

I had decided not to fall.

Because there were people I had to protect. The Fire King and Cheongpung had fought for my sake, so even if I had to become a ghost instead of some supernatural being, I had to stop this bastard.

“So…”

I gathered every last scrap of internal energy. The meager handful of qi flowed unsteadily toward the spearhead.

A faint wisp of Spear Energy lit the darkness like a firefly.

“Quit spouting bullshit and come at me, you bastard with a supernatural-powers fetish.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord fell silent.

Countless emotions passed across his face. When they were gone, only a pair of deeply solemn eyes remained.

Swish!

Chapter 360

I didn’t know how much time had passed.

Time crawled for me, while the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s rushed by as swift and violent as the Yangtze’s current I had seen a few weeks ago.

One thing was certain: even now, at this very moment, time kept moving.

Thud!

I saw neither a windup nor the movement itself. By the time I realized the Western Heaven Demon Lord had taken a step, my head had already snapped back.

Before I could even regain my balance, the sound of splitting air pierced my ears.

Shhk, thud! Thud-thud-thud!

Shoulder, chest, stomach.

Palm and fist, each laden with internal energy, hammered my upper body in fluid succession.

My bones shifted with sickening cracks, and agony washed my vision white. I gritted my teeth.

Crk.

A molar shattered, and for a brief moment, my mind cleared.

“Raaaagh!”

Whoosh!

With a cry squeezed from the depths of my lungs, I swung my fist.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord caught my hopelessly slow, wide-open punch and clicked his tongue.

“You still have strength left?”

“…!”

Crack!

Even muscles and bones hardened like steel were nothing more than kindling before the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

His hook-like hand seized my wrist and twisted. Flesh and bone were crushed together.

The bones in my already broken left arm splintered, sending horrific pain through me.

“Gaaaaaagh!”

“Don’t worry. I’ll summon some skilled healers to treat you later.”

“Go… fuck yourself!”

I thrust my still-usable right arm at the Western Heaven Demon Lord as he wiped the blood splattered across his face.

White Flame's spearhead, wreathed in faint Spear Energy, stabbed toward his lower body.

Whoosh. Clack.

But the spearhead was stopped with absurd ease.

Not by the Black Dragon Armor or Body-Protecting Qi, but by the Western Heaven Demon Lord's bare hand.

"Futile."

His hand, wrapped in ink-black Force, tightened around the spearhead. The faint energy gathered there vanished as though swallowed by darkness.

"Give up. The outcome won't change."

With those quiet words, the Western Heaven Demon Lord yanked on the spearhead.

I clung desperately to the shaft as it tried to slip from my flayed, blood-soaked grip.

Searing pain surged through me, but it was bearable.

Pain was something I'd endured more than enough of, both in the past and now.

Whoosh, crash!

I tumbled forward with the spear shaft. A handful of dirt entered my mouth and mixed with the blood.

The ice-cold, foul-smelling floor of the underground prison somehow felt more comfortable than ever.

I'm sleepy.

If I closed my eyes now, I felt as though I could fall asleep immediately.

Maybe after dreaming one long dream for days on end, I would wake up in the modern world instead of Murim.

A plush seat on a private plane bound for Sichuan, China, would be fine. So would my room at Hope Goshiwon, steeped in the musty smell of a bachelor living alone.[1784]

Maybe all of this is a dream.

I had been through too much in the space of little more than a year.

From F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung to the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. From a disgrace who dragged his family's name through the mud to the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

I had witnessed brutal wars and countless deaths. I had met so many people.

Jin Wikyung, who absolutely doted on his younger brother, and Jin Mukyung, who would have loved to kill his. Hyuk Mujin, who had shared life and death with me while always remaining at my side. Cheongpung, who was both my friend and my rival.

And…

[1784] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent arrangement common in South Korea.

Old Master.

My eyelids, which had been slowly sliding shut without my realizing it, stopped.

That's right. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

He was behind me, and I stood before him.

That was why I could neither fall nor run away.

That arrogant bastard. Taekyung, go on ahead.

H-hyung![1785]

I'll catch up soon.

Three years had already passed, but I would never forget what happened that day.

I had failed to protect the people precious to me, and I had survived through their sacrifice.

Yet even after gaining power beyond anything my past self could have imagined, I had repeated the same mistake.

What do you think? The Dance of the Fire God and Demon. Pretty damn incredible, isn't it?

Jeok Cheongang had been smiling then.

That smile held the joy of avenging his closest friend—and the relief of protecting one little brat he couldn't tell was his disciple or his enemy.

"Yes. It's incredible…"

A small voice escaped through my torn, swollen lips.

The floor of the underground prison no longer felt comfortable.

Feeling its bitter cold and stench, I began to push myself up.

I braced my still-usable right arm against the floor and supported myself on both knees.

My body felt ready to break apart at any moment, and every movement was slow, but I refused to give up.

When I finally stood upright on my trembling legs, the first thing I encountered was a pair of deeply sunken eyes.

"Impressive. Almost foolishly so."

Thud!

My nose broke, and my head snapped backward. But I did not fall or stagger back.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's hand held my shoulder like a shackle.

"How many times must I tell you? It's already over."

Crunch.

The bones in my shoulder were crushed. The spear shaft slipped limply from my weakened grip.

Horrific pain should have followed, but what I actually felt was faint and distant.

[1785] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“If you’re waiting for help, you’ve miscalculated. The Sichuan Tang Clan will be destroyed. No, it may all be over already.”

Crack!

This time, it was my legs.

Both shins—the only parts of me still intact—broke at once, and I lost my balance.

Ironically, the only reason I remained upright was that the Western Heaven Demon Lord had not let go.

“Who could possibly come to your aid as they did in Henan? The Sword Saint, who won’t hear this news for another half month? The Sword Saint’s successor, who is likely fighting desperately even now? Or perhaps…”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord turned his head.

Beyond the empty underground prison, shattered and collapsed by our clash, his gaze settled upon a tightly shut iron door.

“Your master, who still hasn’t regained consciousness?”

“Cough.”

“Nothing will change. Today, the Tang Clan, Qingcheng, and Emei will be destroyed. And all of you…”

“Cough!”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s words cut off.

A sticky liquid of dirt and blood covered his face.

He clearly had not expected someone with all four limbs crushed to do such a thing.

For one fleeting instant, he froze with his hand around my neck.

I drove my head forward with every ounce of strength I had left.

Thud!

The heavy impact snapped the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s head back.

My internal energy had run dry long ago, and my severe Internal Injuries made it difficult to move even a single finger. I did not know where that strength had come from. I did not even know myself.

And…

It’s not like I have time to think about it anymore.

That had been my final act of defiance.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord rubbed his reddened forehead and let out a quiet laugh.

“You truly are… a dangerous man.”

I answered in a faint, unfocused voice.

“I should’ve cracked your skull.”

“If I hadn’t raised my Body-Protecting Qi at the last moment, you might have.”

"You monstrous bastard."

"Hah. It feels strange hearing that from you."

Unfathomable emotions flickered through the Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes as he looked at me.

At first glance, they seemed like anger. At the same time, they felt almost like admiration.

Before I could make sense of them, an unexpected roar rang out.

Rumble-rumble-rumble, boom!

The sound had come from neither me nor the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

The underground prison.

The entire vast space, thousands of feet across, shook. Fist-sized stones fell from the ceiling, and cracks spread across the ground.

The noise and tremors soon subsided, but a deep furrow appeared between the Western Heaven Demon Lord's brows.

"…I'd better hurry."

The instant he muttered those words and glanced at the ceiling, heaven and earth flipped.

A moment later, a slight impact traveled through my back.

Boom!

A wall.

He had thrown me against it.

"Cough."

As I spat up blood, his calm voice reached my ears.

"Sit there for a while. I'll be back soon."

"You…"

"If you're still alive by then, I'll take you with me. If you happen to be dead…"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord paused before continuing.

"That wouldn't be so bad either. You're a dangerous man."

"W-wait."

I reached with all the strength I had left toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord's retreating back.

I had to stop him. I had to keep him from capturing Jeok Cheongang and the Divine Physician.

But not a single part of my body would move as I wanted.

"Cough. Bleegh!"

Dark-red blood gushed from my open mouth.

The chunks mixed in with it were…

Damn it. Pieces of my organs.

It was neither my first time seeing such a thing nor an unexpected sight, but crushing despair weighed down my entire body.

My limbs were crippled, and I had suffered a fatal Internal Injury.

In my heart, I had already thrown myself into the Western Heaven Demon Lord's path. But with my arms and legs crushed, I couldn't take a single step.

"Ah."

I raised my head blankly with a groan.

The corridor where the Western Heaven Demon Lord had disappeared stood empty.

The place, devastated by our clash, was filled with traces of craters large and small, collapsed walls, and other destruction.

The prison where prisoners had still been confined half a day earlier was now strewn with bent bars, fallen rocks, and things like broken chains.

The sight made me realize it.

It's over.

I had fought, and I had lost.

I had tried to stop him, but I couldn't. I had tried to protect them, but I had failed.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had been telling the truth.

The kind of luck we had seen in Henan would not happen again. The Tang Clan, Emei, and Qingcheng were headed for destruction, and Cheongpung could not handle them all alone.

He'll probably die or be captured.

I wished he would run instead, but that would never happen.

That was the kind of person Cheongpung was. Even drenched in blood, he would return to the underground prison to save his Benefactor.

I stared into the darkness beyond, where the exit lay, and laughed weakly.

Damn it…

It all felt like my fault.

Cheongpung. Jeok Cheongang. Even the Divine Physician, who had been dragged into this mess for no reason and would suffer because of it.

At least Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang had not come with me. That was the only thing I could be grateful for.

Rumble-rumble-rumble.

A slight tremor ran through the ground, accompanied by a roar that seemed to rise from the depths of the earth.

The sound announcing the end of the match.

There had been no need to go twelve rounds like in boxing. I had fallen after only three, and I would probably die soon.

I'm sorry. All of you.

The capsule’s instruction manual had contained one simple rule.

If you die in the Murim, you die in reality, too.

Everything I had built while traveling between those two worlds was crumbling little by little, just like this underground prison.

“I never thought I’d die like this…”

My vision blurred. The pain throughout my body and the sounds reaching my ears slowly faded away.

Then, just as I was about to slip free of every sensation, an old man’s face suddenly appeared before me.

A chain with marks where something had torn it away.

An unusually tall body, so gaunt that every bone stood out.

I called to him in a feeble voice.

“…Heavenly Power Demon.”

Chapter 361

Step. Step.

There was not the slightest trace of urgency or hesitation in the Western Heaven Demon Lord's stride.

Not even fragments of rock falling from the ceiling to herald the collapse, nor the pitch-black darkness blocking his path, could change that.

The Four Great Demon Lords were beings entitled to walk that way.

Only one thing concerned him: the possibility that he might fail to carry out the exalted Lord of Heaven's command.

Jin Taekyung. That child held me up for quite some time.

He had never imagined Taekyung would delay him for so long.

As Jin Taekyung came to mind, the Western Heaven Demon Lord unconsciously rubbed his forehead.

He felt a swollen lump beneath his fingers, throbbing with pain. It bothered him more than his torn palm or the blood running down his forearm.

A lump.

Jin Taekyung had been hanging there with all four limbs broken.

His internal energy had clearly been exhausted, and his Internal Injury was severe enough that it would not have been strange for an ordinary Peak master to have died already…

"To think my Body-Protecting Qi couldn't completely stop it."

The Western Heaven Demon Lord let out a hollow laugh.

Jin Taekyung had pierced his Body-Protecting Qi with his mere flesh and wounded him. By ordinary common sense, such a thing was utterly impossible.

Two words surfaced in the Western Heaven Demon Lord's mind.

With everything he had.

Prepared to die.

Is this not supernatural powers in its truest form?

It was unbearably fascinating. At the same time, it sent a chill through his heart.

In terms of martial arts realm, Cheongpung, who had already reached the Supreme Peak, was unquestionably ahead.

But Jin Taekyung felt dangerous for a different reason.

He is strong simply because he is human.

Martial arts far beyond what any Peak master should possess. Tenacity that surpassed all imagination.

Had Jin Taekyung's strength not run out when it did, the Western Heaven Demon Lord would have ended his life without hesitation.

But now, everything was proceeding smoothly toward its conclusion.

“Is this the place?”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stopped before a firmly shut iron door. In an underground prison made up mostly of barred cells, the treatment room’s enormous iron door stood out immediately.

Of course, even without such an obvious landmark, it could never have escaped the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s Qi Sense.

No mistake.

Without hesitation, he brought down a hand blade.

The Force coating its edge sliced effortlessly through the handspan-thick steel door and its locking mechanism.

Shhk! Boom!

The bisected iron door crashed to the floor with a deafening roar.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord strode into the treatment room. He spotted someone and smiled faintly.

“Are you the Divine Physician?”

An old man sat in a chair beside a bed made of Cold-Ice Stone. He opened his eyes.

His voice was calm.

“That is merely an empty title bestowed upon me by the people of this world.”

“I have heard plenty of rumors about you. They say no one knows your name or age—not even whether you are a man or a woman. I have wanted to meet you at least once.”

“And now that you have, what do you think?”

“You look much as I imagined. More like an immortal, even, than those Daoist[1786] bastards who put on lofty airs as though they lived above the clouds.”

The Divine Physician sighed.

“I wish that were true. If this old man were an immortal, I would also possess the power to drive away fiends.”

“Do I look like a fiend?”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord spread his arms wide and spun in a circle.

He had an ordinary face and an ordinary build. Were it not for his long robe, torn to shreds and soaked in blood, he could have been any unremarkable middle-aged man.

“When the Lord of Heaven descends from the heavens to the mortal realm, four loyal servants stand beneath His almighty power.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord continued in a gentle voice.

[1786] Daoists are followers of Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition.

“I am neither a fiend nor an immortal. I am merely a servant who follows His command.”

…!

The sincerity in his voice made the Divine Physician’s eyelids tremble.

The Lord of Heaven? A servant? Whatever the man meant, there could be no doubt that he was utterly insane.

“What nonsense! If you are not a fiend despite slaughtering people without hesitation, then what are you?”

“It is unfortunate. But what can I do? Erasing those who oppose His will is part of my duty.”

“Y-you are…”

The Divine Physician was struck speechless as the Western Heaven Demon Lord gave a quiet sigh.

The thick scent of blood soaked into every word he spoke and every small movement he made, enough to make nausea rise in the Divine Physician’s throat.

“Get out.”

“Hm? What did you say?”

“I said get out. No one is permitted to enter while I am treating a patient. Especially a fiend like you.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stared at the Divine Physician’s rigid face, then laughed aloud.

“I thought you were an inflexible physician, but you know how to joke. Divine Physician, the treatment is already over.”

“It is not over.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord advanced with an amused expression. At the end of his path lay Jeok Cheongang, motionless as a corpse.

“I believe the patient should be moved somewhere else.”

“Before that… you should ask the physician’s permission.”

The Divine Physician rose from his seat, his expression hard.

At that very moment—

Pa-pa-pat!

Dozens of streaks of light shot from his billowing sleeves. Needles large and small flew in straight lines or curved through the air toward the lethal acupoint behind the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s neck.

Yet as he watched them hurtle toward him, the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s smile only deepened.

“How interesting.”

Tudududuk!

He did not move.

The formidable Body-Protecting Qi surrounding him simply did its job.

Dozens of needles struck the Body-Protecting Qi and trembled violently.

“And unfortunate.”

Crunch.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord closed his hand, then opened it again. Invisible energy obeyed its master’s will, seizing the needles and crushing them into a mangled mass.

The Divine Physician might have learned martial arts, but the gulf between him and the Western Heaven Demon Lord was as vast as the distance between heaven and earth.

“I’ll say it again. The treatment is over.”

…!

At the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s quiet declaration, the Divine Physician’s body rose into the air.

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space—a feat possible only for someone possessing terrifying internal energy.

The Divine Physician flew forward as if something had flung him. His face turned deathly pale as the Western Heaven Demon Lord caught him by the throat.

“F-fiend…”

“That hardly seems like something a physician who just unleashed a killing technique should say. Come to think of it, wouldn’t that make you a fiend as well?”

“If I think of the blood that will stain your hands, I will gladly become one!”

Whoosh. Thunk.

The Divine Physician’s palm strike, thrust out with a shout that brought up blood, was blocked with ease.

Crack-crack.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord tightened his grip and broke the old physician’s hand. A strange glint passed through his eyes.

“The Tang Family Head was right. You had it.”

His gaze had settled on the Divine Physician’s hand.

Around one wrinkled finger was something wholly unsuited to a physician.

“So this is the Myriad-Poison Ring…”

A band glowing softly, set with a jewel that seemed to contain both light and darkness.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord gazed at the objective of his mission with rapture, as though bewitched. He carefully removed the Myriad-Poison Ring from the Divine Physician’s finger and slipped it onto his own.

“The Lord of Heaven will be pleased.”

The Divine Physician, who had watched everything unfold, let out a suppressed groan.

“W-what are you planning to do?”

“Don’t concern yourself with it. Your role ends here anyway.”

Whoosh! Thud!

A palm strike that shot forward like a blade pierced the Divine Physician’s abdomen.

His lower dantian shattered. The Divine Physician was hurled across the room, vomiting blood.

“Bweeeeegh!”

“It seems I no longer need the physician’s permission. Wouldn’t you agree?”

The Divine Physician despaired, and the Western Heaven Demon Lord laughed heartily.

It was over. At last, he had obtained the Myriad-Poison Ring desired by the Lord of Heaven and erased from this land three great sects whose influence spanned the realm.

Nothing remained that could stand in his way.

It was time to finish everything and return.

“Come. Let us go together. There is someone who wishes to see you.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord whispered to Jeok Cheongang, who slept peacefully atop the Cold-Ice Stone, then used Seizing an Object Through Empty Space to draw him closer.

Or rather, he was about to.

Wooooooong.

…!

A low, faint sound, like a swarm of bees buzzing.

Only the Western Heaven Demon Lord could have noticed it. It was a tremor in the air, a faint vibration that slowly drew nearer.

Could the collapse have already begun?

The Western Heaven Demon Lord turned toward the source.

Beyond the treatment room, its iron door now gone, a faint light flickered in the pitch-black darkness.

“What is that…”

He deliberately furrowed his brow.

The next instant, his eyes flew wide.

Wooooooong! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The vibration intensified. Wind and air tore apart.

And then—

KRAAAAAA!

A massive light shot forward, obliterating the space in its path.

No.

No—a spear wreathed in blue flames.

A name flashed through the Western Heaven Demon Lord's mind, and he could no longer hold back his laughter.

"Supernatural powers! Truly, this is supernatural powers!"

As he threw back his head and laughed, a vast darkness surged up and shot forward.

White Flame, engulfed in blue fire, collided with the darkness.

KABOOOOOM!

Amid the deafening blast that shook the underground prison, a voice rang out.

"The sickroom is off-limits unless you're family or a Disciple. You fucking bastard."

Step. Step.

I pushed through the cloud of dust and moved forward.

Neither the rocks pouring from the ceiling like rain nor the pitch-black darkness before me could stop my steps.

I simply continued toward the one person somewhere beyond it.

What a monster. Not that I expected something like that to kill him.

I couldn't see him, but I could feel him—the immense energy coiled within the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

But it didn't frighten me as much as before.

I calmly clenched my fist. The powerful internal energy overflowing from my entire body felt almost tangible in my hand.

Heavenly Power Demon.

My clash with the Western Heaven Demon Lord had presented him with a new opportunity.

The falling rocks from the collapsing ceiling had broken his restraints, allowing the old man known as a fiend to leave the underground prison for the first time in decades.

And the Heavenly Power Demon's first words to me had been completely unexpected.

You killed all the other prisoners.

Cough. So?

You bastard. Why did you leave me alive?

Did that bother you so much?

Answer the question. I can cut off your breath right now.

Wait a few more moments. It'll give out on its own.

You bastard!

It had been a conversation between two cripples.

One with all four limbs crushed. The other with his Sinews and Meridians already severed.

But the Heavenly Power Demon had one advantage over me.

At least his internal energy remained intact.

I was already dying, and the approaching death frightened me.

I wanted one last conversation with the person watching me die.

I didn't want to kill you.

Why not?

Because at least the man I knew wasn't a fiend.

…!

The way I see it, a good man from the Demonic Cult is better than a bad man from the orthodox faction. If I killed someone like you, I felt like I'd become no different from a fiend myself.

In truth, I had hesitated over and over. Killing the Heavenly Power Demon would have earned me a massive amount of EXP and several level-ups.

After agonizing over it, I had chosen to give that up.

Looking back, it had probably been for the best. The Western Heaven Demon Lord wasn't someone I could defeat with one or two level-ups.

Rather than dying with an unpleasant feeling in my chest, I thought it was better to leave this world feeling relieved.

Well… this isn't so bad either.

The Heavenly Power Demon had stared at me for a long while, his expression complicated, before making me an offer.

An offer I couldn't possibly refuse.

Remembering the Heavenly Power Demon's final words, I swept my hand through the air.

The tremendous wind pressure scattered the cloud of dust, revealing the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

"Your big brother's here."

"Kha! Khahahaha!"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord doubled over like a shrimp, roaring with laughter.

I looked past his shoulder.

A dozen or so meters[1787] behind him, someone stood unsteadily inside the treatment room where the door had been.

The Divine Physician.

His face was deathly pale, but he nodded.

Jeok Cheongang was safe.

Thank goodness. I made it in time.

As I breathed a sigh of relief, the Western Heaven Demon Lord finally stopped laughing and raised his head.

“You’ve changed so much that I hardly recognize you.”

“I got a gift. From someone I never expected.”

“A gift?”

“Yeah. I received internal energy.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord exclaimed in realization.

“Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body!”

“Apparently, that’s what some people call it.”

“Did you use that power you spoke of? The one resembling the Essence-Siphoning Great Technique?”

“No.”

“Then you had a fortuitous encounter. Ha-ha!”

“It wasn’t free. He asked me for one favor.”

“A favor?”

“Yeah.”

I quietly nodded. I remembered the Heavenly Power Demon’s words as he transferred his internal energy to me.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord…

“He asked me to kill you.”

Tudududuk. Grab.

When I reached out, White Flame was pulled free from deep within the wall and caught in my hand.

The fire dragon, swollen by three jiazi[1788] of internal energy, spread its wings.

“You’re… dead.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord smiled broadly.

[1787] A dozen or so meters is about 40 ft.

[1788] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi represents 180 years of internal energy.

Chapter 362

The Western Heaven Demon Lord spoke with a laugh.

“I admit it. You are supernatural powers incarnate.”

He had crushed all four of Jin Taekyung’s limbs with his own hands and inflicted severe Internal Injuries.

Crippled? He would have been fortunate if that were all. His wounds had been more than enough to kill him.

And yet the young man, Jin Taekyung, had survived.

He had returned to stand before the Western Heaven Demon Lord with his limbs restored without a single scar and even greater internal energy than before.

Even dozens of sorcerers working together couldn’t achieve a recovery like this.

If this wasn’t supernatural powers—an outright miracle—what was?

The Western Heaven Demon Lord trembled with a sudden surge of excitement and wonder.

Seeing him like that, Jin Taekyung cocked his head and sneered.

“What? Thinking about dying soon making you need to piss? Why are you shaking so much?”

“Do you know how many years I have lived?”

“No. Don’t want to, either.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord nodded.

“Of course. To be honest, I don’t know myself.”

“Are you an idiot?”

“As I grew older, counting the years began to feel meaningless. Had I gone on living as I was, I might have grown so weary of the boredom that I chose death.”

“Can’t you die now? I’m serious. I’d even get down on my knees and beg.”

“I’m afraid I’m enjoying myself more than ever. Today, I met you, just as I once met the Lord of Heaven.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord smiled brightly once more.

For him, the past several decades had been tedious years of endurance.

He missed war and blood. He yearned for something he had never experienced before.

Something new that even the Poison King and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun had failed to provide.

The young man before him possessed the very thing the Western Heaven Demon Lord had longed for.

“I have only one request.”

The corners of the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s mouth stretched wide.

With his face grotesquely twisted into a smile, he resembled a fiend from the Lotus Sutra.[1789]

“Try to hold out as long as you can.”

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The ground shook violently.

Black qi streamed from the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s entire body, bearing down on everything around him.

The absolute master, possessed of power that could shatter heaven, brought down his darkness-shrouded sword. Ink-black Sword Force surged forward, erasing the space in its path.

Whooooooosh!

“I’ve got one request, too.”

The young man, Jin Taekyung, tightened his grip on his spear.

Blue flames enveloped the spearhead, illuminating the darkness like sacred fire.

“Try to die as fast as you can.”

KABOOM!

A deafening boom shook heaven and earth, and a massive impact traveled down the spearhead.

Krrrk!

A thrill rushed through me as I stared at the ink-black Sword Force clashing with White Flame.

I have a good chance of winning.

That single exchange was enough to convince me.

Sword Force against Spear Energy.

Ask which was superior, and ninety-nine out of a hundred people would answer Sword Force.

The last one would probably give you shit for asking something so obvious.

But…

This is doable.

During my first battle with the Western Heaven Demon Lord, every exchange had inflicted an Internal Injury and forced me back.

But the immense internal energy the Heavenly Power Demon had given me through Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body changed everything.

I had retreated only one step.

[1789] The Lotus Sutra is a major scripture of Mahayana Buddhism.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had once seemed impossibly distant. Now he was close enough to touch if I reached out.

"Internal energy sure is nice, huh? Don't you think?"

Zzzzzzt.

My absurdly massive Spear Energy showed no sign of dimming, even against the ink-black Sword Force.

Beyond our crossed weapons, the Western Heaven Demon Lord regarded me with open admiration.

"I guarantee there has never been a Peak master like you in the history of the Murim."

"Of course not. They probably didn't have more than three jiazi[1790] of internal energy."

I looked him straight in the eye and added,

"Or an ability like this."

Before I had even finished speaking, I was already issuing a command in my mind.

Assign fifty points each to Strength and Agility.

Internal energy wasn't the only thing the Heavenly Power Demon had given me.

Ten Level Ups had healed every injury on my body, and I still had all the Stat Points that came with them.

Whoooooosh.

A dazzling halo of light enveloped my entire body.

The change, perceptible only to me, took place in an instant.

Now it was time to see the results for myself.

"Put some real strength into your 'don't-go.'"

"Don't-go?"

"Your asshole, dumbass."

I was going to make him shit himself.

Clenching my teeth, I poured strength into the hand gripping the spear shaft.

Grrrrrk.

What were my stats now?

I didn't know the exact numbers, but one thing was certain.

At the very least, this body had already gone far beyond the limits of a human being.

The smile vanished from the Western Heaven Demon Lord's face beneath the overwhelming pressure.

"This is ridiculously crude…!"

"Way to hit me where it hurts."

[1790] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi are 180 years.

It was crude enough to leave anyone speechless, but it was also brutally effective.

The spear, which had been slowly giving way beneath the Sword Force, began to tilt ever so slightly toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

If my martial arts aren't enough, I'll make up the difference with my body.

It was a method only I could use in this world.

At the same time, it proved that the Western Heaven Demon Lord's martial arts stood far above mine.

"Ha!"

Krrrk!

The instant a sharp shout burst from the Western Heaven Demon Lord's mouth, his sword traced a strange arc and coiled around the spearhead.

He was redirecting my attack with the principle of Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties.

The spearhead plunged into empty air, releasing an explosion of compressed air.

As I staggered, the Western Heaven Demon Lord thrust out his hand.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Invisible, formless qi.

I couldn't see it, but I could sense it—where it would strike and when.

With that realization, my body flowed into motion.

I bent backward until my back nearly touched the ground.

Pfft!

Five strands of Finger Qi shot from the Western Heaven Demon Lord's hand and grazed my philtrum.

Blood sprayed, filling my nose with its coppery smell.

By the time I sprang upright with a carp-leaping maneuver, the ink-black Sword Force was already slicing diagonally across my body.

Whoooooosh! Shhk!

It missed me by a hair and tore through space.

That alone brought down a pillar three zhang[1791] away and split the bars of the underground prison like tofu.

We were too close for me to swing my spear.

But I already knew what to do.

Inventory open. Store.

White Flame vanished from my hand, and I thrust both arms toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord's chest.

Whooosh!

Scorching heat mingled with my breath.

[1791] Three zhang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); one zhang is ten ja.

My palms, imbued with the power of Flame Divine Palm, shot forward. At the same moment, the Western Heaven Demon Lord released his sword.

His hands blurred as he slammed both palms into mine.

KABOOM!

The instant our four palms, each carrying tremendous internal energy, collided, a violent gale erupted around us.

The rocky ground caved in, and the force of the impact blasted apart everything nearby.

But the real struggle had only begun.

Hngh!

I smothered the groan rising in my throat.

An immense wave of energy poured through our locked palms and intertwined fingers, making my vision swim.

What the hell is with this bastard's internal energy…?

I currently possessed a full three jiazi[1792] of internal energy.

In terms of sheer internal energy, that was more than enough to stand shoulder to shoulder with the Sect Leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

But the Western Heaven Demon Lord—the monster standing before me—was on an entirely different level.

This is insane.

Hisssssss.

The heat gathered in my hands slowly faded as darkness devoured the flames.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord spoke in a low voice.

"There is no need to feel so aggrieved. A tower easily built is just as easily toppled."

"…!"

"You are merely a strong child. Such is the limit of those who have failed to cross the wall."

Limit?

That single word made my teeth clench.

I had heard it until I was sick of it.

A bastard raised without a father. A bastard from a poor family. A bastard doomed to remain an F-rank Hunter until the day he died…

Every cutting remark anyone had ever aimed at me had come with the same word attached like a tag.

Even now, after everything I had accomplished.

"I swear, I'm going to…"

[1792] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi are 180 years.

A question mark appeared over the Western Heaven Demon Lord's face at my suppressed voice.

Holding back the endless torrent of his internal energy, I forced out the words like a groan.

"I'm going to circumcise that mouth of yours."

"…!"

It didn't take long for the question mark on his face to turn into an exclamation mark.

I ground my teeth and summoned every last bit of strength I had. My body, which had been sliding backward, began inching forward.

Then I slowly bent the Western Heaven Demon Lord's interlocked fingers.

Crack!

Bones shifted out of place, and his brow furrowed.

"When it comes to brute strength, you may well be the best under heaven. But this is as far as you go."

Crack-crack-crack! Thud!

It happened in an instant.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stepped on empty air, launched himself upward, and drove his knee into my face.

The bridge of my newly healed nose caved in, and several broken teeth spun through the air.

I hurriedly pulled my hand away and wiped the blood covering my eyes.

"Ghk!"

"Your limit is clear."

Whoosh—bang!

A fist hurtled toward me with a violent crack of displaced air.

I raised an arm to shield myself, but the shockwave ruptured my eardrums.

As I staggered, punches and kicks rained down.

Thud-thud-thud-thud-thud!

Chest. Stomach. Legs.

The relentless barrage battered my entire body.

But unlike our first battle, I neither let his attacks land so easily nor fell beneath them.

I've already been through this once. I won't let it happen twice.

I reached into a pale afterimage and caught something solid.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's arm—the part even the Black Dragon Armor left exposed.

Without the slightest hesitation, I twisted it.

No.

I wrung it out like wet laundry.

Krrrk!

His skin tore, and shards of splintered bone burst through.

No matter how great the master, he could still feel pain. The Western Heaven Demon Lord let out a stifled groan and threw a punch.

His movement was duller and rougher than before.

There was no reason I couldn't avoid it.

Bang!

Compressed air exploded half a span[1793] from my face.

I shot out my arm like lightning and caught his fist.

That was when I saw it.

"Huh?"

Something familiar caught my eye, and I froze.

A ring set with a small gemstone that radiated a mysterious light.

It was almost strange that I hadn't noticed it sooner.

Why does he have the Myriad-Poison Ring…?

In that impossibly brief instant, a thousand thoughts flashed through my mind.

And after the flash of insight came the Western Heaven Demon Lord's attack.

Crack!

I had let myself get distracted in the middle of a fight. Of course I couldn't dodge it.

The blow sent me tumbling across the ground. I staggered back to my feet, clutching my ringing head.

I had taken the hit, but I couldn't stop laughing like a madman.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord frowned.

"Why are you laughing? Have you lost your mind?"

"Lost my mind? You're the crazy one, dumbass."

Still laughing, I waved the object in my hand.

See this?

A fresh new Item, still warm after being stored in my Inventory and pulled right back out.

"What are you going to do if you lose something important? Huh?"

"…!"

A host of emotions flashed across the Western Heaven Demon Lord's face when he saw the Myriad-Poison Ring.

Shock. Surprise. Confusion.

Then anger.

[1793] Half a handspan is approximately 10 cm (4 in).

He looked down at his suddenly empty hand and spoke in a heavy voice.

“How?”

“Who knows? Maybe it’s those supernatural powers you love so much.”

A single brush had been enough.

The Myriad-Poison Ring had left the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s hand and been safely stored in my private vault—the Inventory, where no one else could reach it.

Now I slipped it onto my middle finger.

“You can tell it’s a sacred treasure. Look at that shine. Pretty, isn’t it?”

“Give it back. It is not something the likes of you can possess.”

I raised my middle finger at the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

“What do you think? Looks good?”

“…!”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord trembled with rage.

His usual composure had vanished without a trace.

Seeing him like that finally confirmed it.

“The Myriad-Poison Ring. This was your objective from the very beginning.”

The moment I saw the ring on the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s finger, the first thing that came to mind was the Green Jade Buddha Staff, the sacred treasure of Shaolin Temple that the Blood Lord had stolen during the massacre at Shaolin.

“I figured there had to be something special about it when that bastard clung to it even while running for his life… What, are you people collecting orbs? You think a dragon will appear and grant you a wish if you gather seven?”[1794]

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes darkened.

“I told you to give it back.”

“Yeah. Fuck off.”

I waved the middle finger wearing the Myriad-Poison Ring right in his face.

At the same time, I muttered inwardly.

Inventory open. Store.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes widened as the Myriad-Poison Ring vanished without a trace, as though erased by an eraser.

“You…!”

Rumble-rumble-rumble.

The qi around him churned violently.

The sword he summoned with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space flew into his grasp.

[1794] A reference to *Dragon Ball*, in which gathering seven Dragon Balls summons a wish-granting dragon.

Tss-tss-tss-tss!

Ink-black Sword Force blazed around the blade, fiercer and more violent than ever.

“This is the last time. Hand it over.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was no longer the same now that he had lost what mattered most.

His mind was shaken, and a shaken mind made for a shaken sword.

That might be enough to turn the tide.

“I’ll give you my final answer, then. No.”

The moment the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes sank deeply at my answer—

“You brought this upon yourself.”

At those emotionless words, the ink-black Sword Force coiling around his blade shot forward like an arrow.

But its devastating power wasn’t aimed at my arms, my legs, or my neck.

At the far end of the ruined corridor stood the treatment room.

“No!”

I launched myself forward with a scream.

The muscles throughout my body, swollen to the point of bursting, shrieked in pain.

The internal energy I desperately dragged up clawed at my heart meridian.

But none of that mattered.

As long as I could stop it.

As long as I wasn’t too late.

Old Master!

With the cry trapped inside my throat, I kicked off the ground once more.

KABOOOOOM!

In a world slowed to a crawl, a deafening roar like heaven splitting apart filled my ears, and a blinding flash swallowed my vision.

Chapter 363

KABOOOOOM!

A tremendous roar and shockwave slammed into my entire body.

My vision swam. The ceiling and floor traded places, and my hair whipped around me. My body flew helplessly through the air and crashed into a corner of the treatment room.

Crack!

A sharp current raced up my spine, and something hot surged up from deep within my lungs.

“Ghk!”

Dark red blood spilled across the floor. It was obvious proof that I had suffered a serious Internal Injury.

And I had.

Damn it. How long has it even been since I recovered?

The only consolation was that my injuries weren’t as severe as before and that I had managed to protect the treatment room from the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s Sword Force.

“Are you all right?”

At my question, the Divine Physician lifted his head from where he had curled up in a corner of the treatment room.

He was covered in pale dust, with Jeok Cheongang cradled in his arms. After letting out a quiet groan, he answered.

“Thanks to Young Master Jin blocking the attack, I am safe.”

But despite his answer, the Divine Physician was clearly far from all right.

His beard, white as an immortal’s, was stained with blood. His wrist was bent at an unnatural angle, and through the tatters of his clothes, I could see dark bruises covering his lower abdomen.

That’s…

There was no doubt about it. The Divine Physician’s dantian was ruined. Having lost all the martial arts he possessed, he was now nothing more than an ordinary old man.

No—with his qi-sea acupoint destroyed and his arm broken, his condition was anything but good.

Even after all that, he still protected Old Master…

Not a single scratch marred Jeok Cheongang’s body. The old physician had disregarded his own safety to protect his patient.

“Old Man Dong.”

“This old man is fine, so do not worry.”

The Divine Physician gave me a faint smile, then looked at me with concern.

"More importantly, I am worried about Young Master Jin's condition. This old man will come to you, so please wait just a moment—"

Instead of answering, I reached out.

Formless internal energy flowed from my fingertips and gently pushed back the Divine Physician as he tried to approach me.

"Y-Young Master Jin?"

Before the Divine Physician could finish speaking, a streak of Finger Qi shot through the air from somewhere beyond us and pierced the wall.

It had passed through the exact spot where the Divine Physician's head had been only moments ago.

Shhk! Pfft!

Had I been even one second later—no, even a quarter of a second—the Divine Physician would already have been dead.

I gestured for the physician, now frozen like a rock, to take cover. Then I turned and stared straight ahead.

"That's pretty low, going after a helpless old man."

Beyond the clouds of dust parting like the Red Sea, the Western Heaven Demon Lord finally appeared.

A chilling voice slipped between his lips.

"Low? You were the one who threw away the opportunity I gave you."

His usual composure and refined manner of speaking had long since vanished. Concentrated killing intent burned in his eyes as he stared at me.

"You touched something you should never have touched."

"Fuck, anyone listening to you would think the Myriad-Poison Ring was an erogenous zone. You're an old bastard who can't even get it up anymore."

"…!"

I used White Flame as a cane and pushed myself to my feet.

Every bone in my body throbbed as if it were about to break. Judging by the pain, some of them probably had cracked. On top of that, I had suffered a severe Internal Injury.

Damn it. He was already a monster to begin with.

For a moment, I regretted provoking him.

I had never imagined that a Supreme Peak master like the Western Heaven Demon Lord would resort without hesitation to tactics fit for some Third Rate dark-path thug.

But…

"This must be that important to you. Right?"

I waved the Myriad-Poison Ring I had just taken out of my Inventory.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord, who had seemed impossible to stop, halted abruptly.

“Hand it over at once—”

“You want it back? That won’t be difficult.”

“You intend to negotiate?”

“You catch on fast.”

The Myriad-Poison Ring was nothing more than a strange ring to me—no more and no less.

But it was different for the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

He valued this tiny ring more than the destruction of the Sichuan Tang Clan, Qingcheng, and Emei.

Just like the Blood Lord, who had desperately taken the Green Jade Buddha Staff with him even as his arm was severed.

“Take your lackeys outside and withdraw at once. Otherwise, you’ll never see the Myriad-Poison Ring again.”

“Never see it again…”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord brushed back his hair, stiff with blood.

After a brief silence, a low voice slipped from his lips.

“Ridiculous.”

“What?”

“How could it not be ridiculous? I need only kill you all and take it.”

“…”

“Nothing will change. Not for you, your master, or the Divine Physician. None of you can escape death.”

Even if I explained it, the Western Heaven Demon Lord wouldn’t properly understand the concepts of subspace or the Inventory.

Maybe he was right. Perhaps killing me really would cause everything inside my Inventory to spill out.

But the Western Heaven Demon Lord had overlooked one thing.

“Well, that sounds plausible enough. But you should’ve considered the possibility that I might destroy the Myriad-Poison Ring first.”

My grip was strong enough to crumple steel like paper. Even without circulating internal energy, reducing this little ring to powder would be easy.

“So don’t get any bright ideas. Back off. If you take even one more step—”

Step.

I could not finish my sentence as I stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord. He took a step forward without hesitation and smiled.

“What? Are you flustered?”

He didn’t wait for my answer. Looking delighted beyond measure, he continued.

“It is truly amusing. You call it a sacred treasure, yet you do not actually believe it is one.”

“What is that supposed to mean?”

“My mistake. I thought you would understand after hearing that much.”

The smile vanished from the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s lips. His eyes bored into me, filled with scorn and contempt.

“Did you really think a mere human made of flesh and blood could do anything to a sacred treasure imbued with such great power?”

“…!”

I looked down at the Myriad-Poison Ring resting in my palm.

A sacred treasure passed down through the generations of the Sichuan Tang Clan. One of the old legends of the Murim. A strange ring said to detoxify and absorb any poison under heaven.

And…

The Myriad-Poison Ring can’t even be appraised by the System.

A sacred treasure.

The single word flashed through my mind, and my heart seemed to drop into my stomach. Something ran down my back—whether it was blood or cold sweat, I could not tell.

Drip. Drip.

My fist clenched reflexively, and drops of blood fell from it.

Even beneath my terrifying grip, the Myriad-Poison Ring didn’t so much as bend. Instead, it dug into my palm like a thorn.

“Damn it.”

I muttered under my breath.

There could be no more compromise. No retreat.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord advanced toward me with a jaunty step.

“I regret what this means for the Blood Lord, but…”

Tss-tss-tss-tss!

“I will have to kill you.”

Black mist poured from his entire body and swallowed the treatment room.

Pa-pa-pat!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s figure vanished.

He erased the distance of several zhang[1795] in a single step and swung his ink-black Sword Force. Solid rock split apart like tofu.

[1795] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, about 3.3 meters (11 ft).

I ducked beneath the attack and thrust my spear forward like an arrow.

Bang!

The spearhead stabbed into empty air, and compressed air exploded.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord caught the shaft with a hand wreathed in Force and clicked his tongue.

“You still cannot let go.”

At the same time, the tip of his foot struck my wrist.

The blow targeted not the bone but an acupoint. Pain like a massive needle stabbing into my veins shot through me, and the spear fell from my grip.

But I didn’t give up.

I’d been ready to take him down with me from the very beginning.

I could not fall from something like this.

Either he died, or I did.

And if even that was impossible, I would throw my life away to make sure we died together.

Without the help of the others, it would not have been strange if I had already died several times.

Now it was time to repay that debt—with interest.

“Hngh!”

With a shout that was almost a groan, I grabbed the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s ankle.

He let out a roar and drove a palm into me.

Boom!

A small explosion went off inside my body.

The foul internal energy penetrated through bone and flesh, tearing my heart meridian to shreds.

My vision blurred, and the strength drained from my legs.

But the hand locked around the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s ankle like a shackle kept moving, driven by the will and instinct carved into my mind.

Krrrk!

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes widened in pain.

His Body-Protecting Qi could block my Spear Energy, but it couldn’t stop his ankle from breaking beneath raw physical strength.

Damn it, my hand…

Of course, I had to pay the price for my reckless act.

The hand that had seized his Body-Protecting Qi barehanded was blackened as though it had been shocked by high-voltage electricity. On top of that, I had suffered another Internal Injury that worsened my already terrible condition.

At the moment my grip loosened against my will and my body staggered—

"GRAH!"

A belated scream burst from the Western Heaven Demon Lord's mouth.

His ankle had been wrung out like wet laundry beneath my tremendous grip. White bone showed through the mangled flesh, all of it drenched in blood.

No matter how far someone had advanced into the Supreme Peak realm, everyone had limits.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had displayed unbelievable martial prowess, but he didn't possess infinite internal energy or stamina.

And unlike me, he couldn't recover through Level Ups.

This is my only chance.

I charged at the staggering Western Heaven Demon Lord.

I endured the pain that made it feel as though my limbs were being torn apart and drew up my internal energy. It flowed into both fists, then blazed into flame.

Whoooooosh!

"Jin Taekyung!"

Heat filled the space.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord stood right in front of me, shouting my name through bloodshot eyes.

Pain had made him drop his sword, leaving his hand empty. It was too late for him to block my attack.

If I reached out—if I merely extended my hand—I could deal the Western Heaven Demon Lord a devastating blow.

But then. Then why…

Why did I feel this way?

A strange sensation seized me.

The world had slowed around me.

Everything moving within it was so slow that it made me want to yawn.

It was the same sensation I had felt while facing Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

But this time, the sensation was incomparably sharper. An alarm rang in my mind, and at the same time, I sensed something chilling digging into the back of my neck from behind.

Ah.

So that was it.

A flash of insight struck me.

I pulled back the hand reaching toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord and twisted my head aside.

At that moment, time—which had briefly seemed to have its pause button pressed—began moving again.

Swooooooosh!

Like a dam bursting, several things happened at once.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's sword, wrapped in ink-black Sword Force, grazed the back of my neck.

When I thrust both palms forward again, the Western Heaven Demon Lord's fist smashed into my side.

KRAK!

My ribs broke, and blood surged up my throat.

I was hurled away at bullet-like speed. With great difficulty, I raised my head.

Through my distant, hazy vision, I saw the Western Heaven Demon Lord standing upright.

Perhaps it was because of that strange sensation.

Or perhaps it was the pain.

But the face I saw was filled not with joy or satisfaction, but with shock and fury.

"You dodged my Qi-Controlled Sword?"

Right. The Qi-Controlled Sword.

I'd forgotten he could do that too.

I let out a short laugh as I spat up blood.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes trembled as he stared at me.

"Enlightenment, even at a moment like this… You are someone who must never be allowed to live."

Enlightenment.

So that was what this was.

I flexed my fingers.

The flow of qi and the sensations running through me were clearer than ever.

Along with the pain that already ruled my entire body.

But it's too late.

Step. Step.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's approaching footsteps rang like thunder.

I watched him draw closer through hazy eyes.

Amid the darkness, with stone dust and debris raining down around him, the Western Heaven Demon Lord seemed to ripple like a shadow deeper than the night itself.

"Supernatural powers. You truly were such a being."

I bared my bloodstained teeth and laughed.

My voice stumbled past my lips like a drunkard.

“Fuck off, you… fucking moron.”

“Farewell.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes flashed red in the darkness.

His hand, wrapped in impenetrable darkness, rose high and slowly descended toward the crown of my head.

Whoooooosh.

And then—

“Do not touch a single hair on his head.”

Fwoosh!

Flames bloomed in the darkness as a hoarse voice rang out, as though its owner hadn’t spoken in ages.

Beyond the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s rigid shoulder, someone was rising to his feet.

“Take your hands off what belongs to this old man.”

A small frame.

But a presence as immense as a giant.

I laughed, and the Western Heaven Demon Lord groaned.

“Fire King…!”

Chapter 364

I had a very long dream. A dream of walking through a hundred years of time.

A vagrant child who had wandered the continent begging for scraps met a master, learned martial arts, and made his name known throughout the world. Then one day, he saw his former self in a young beggar stuffing a dirt-covered dumpling into his mouth.

“What’s your name?”

“…I don’t know.”

“Jangcheon. From now on, your name is Jangcheon.”

They were dark, cold memories. On a day when heavy rain poured from the sky, the disciple who had been like his own flesh and blood left, while his master was left behind.

It was only after a very long time that he returned to the world.

And then…

“You’re an interesting fellow. Who did you say you were?”

“Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

He met someone.

A young brat with an irreverent manner and a rebellious gaze he couldn’t hide. Jeok Cheongang hadn’t liked him.

But why had that been?

Whenever he looked around, the brat was always there beside him. Somehow, he kept catching Jeok Cheongang’s eye.

Perhaps that was when his heart had begun to change.

“This old man is already afflicted with the infirmities of old age. Do you truly believe you can learn martial arts from someone like me?”

“Yes.”

“I’ll say this again…”

“I believe in you, Old Master. That’s enough for me.”

Light and warmth seeped into memories that had once been dark and cold.

He never regretted the decision he made that day. Not even when he performed the Dance of the Fire God and Demon for what would be the last time in his life.

“How was it? The Dance of the Fire God and Demon. Pretty incredible, right?”

“Yes. It was incredible.”

Those few words were enough. He wanted nothing more. He had avenged his friend and saved his one and only Disciple.

But the enemy rose again, impossible though it seemed, and that was where his memories ended.

In the darkness where everything had vanished, he wondered.

Am I dead? Where is this place, where neither Yama[1796] nor the dead can be found?

Could I be doomed to wander the underworld?

The question soon faded.

At some point, he lost all sense of time. He even forgot who he was and how he had lived.

No—it was just as he was beginning to forget.

“Old Master. Did you know?”

Someone’s voice echoed faintly in the distance. A voice he had heard somewhere before, speaking words he had never heard that person say.

“I always wanted to call you Master.”

He understood.

At the same time, he remembered the person he had briefly forgotten. The sturdy dam holding back his memories collapsed, and they swallowed him whole.

“I felt the same.”

Fwoosh.

Flames bloomed.

His hands, wreathed in Blazing Flame, tore through the air. The darkness surrounding him in every direction cracked apart, and light seeped through.

The passage was narrow, as though warning him that he was not yet ready to awaken. But without hesitation, he stepped toward the light.

He’s calling me.

Fwoosh!

A blinding white light filled his vision, and the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, opened his eyes.

“Do not touch a single hair on his head.”

His voice was hoarse from long disuse. But when the Western Heaven Demon Lord turned to face him, he felt it.

The heat contained within that small old man’s body.

The flames burning in his eyes.

“Take your hands off what belongs to this old man.”

“Fire King…!”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord let out a low groan.

Of all times, the old monster from Mount Jiuhua had to awaken now.

[1796] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld and judge of the dead.

Under normal circumstances, this might have been manageable. But one of the Demon Lord's ankles had already been crushed, and he had expended a considerable amount of strength.

His opponent, meanwhile, was a Supreme Peak master hailed as the greatest of the Ten Kings.

This is bad. Very bad.

At this rate, he might have to brace himself for a fight that would leave them both gravely wounded.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had no intention of dying here after failing the mission personally entrusted to him by the Lord of Heaven.

I have no choice.

It wounded his pride as a martial artist, but he would have to settle this by the easiest means available.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord bit his lip and extended a hand. Jin Taekyung's limp body, barely clinging to consciousness, flew into his grasp like iron drawn to a magnet.

He seized Jin Taekyung by the throat and shook him for Jeok Cheongang to see.

"You would do well to stop there, if you want your one and only Disciple to live."

Step.

Jeok Cheongang's approaching footsteps stopped dead.

He stared at the Western Heaven Demon Lord, then slowly parted his lips.

"Have you ever seen such a motherless, fatherless, fucking son of a bitch…?"

"…!"

"Did you listen to this old man through your asshole? I told you not to touch a single hair on his head."

The torrent of profanity left the Western Heaven Demon Lord momentarily stunned.

Then a sneer spread across his lips.

"Oh, did you?"

A stifled groan escaped Jin Taekyung's lips as the Western Heaven Demon Lord tightened his grip.

Crunch.

The faint sound of bones shifting out of place echoed through the underground prison.

Jeok Cheongang's eyes darkened.

"You dare…"

"I have many eyes and ears. They all told me the same thing—that the great Fire King cherishes his Disciple as though he were his own flesh and blood."

"…What do you want?"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord answered without hesitation.

“If you don’t want to lose your Disciple, kill yourself.”

“Kill myself?”

Jeok Cheongang let out a hollow laugh and opened his mouth.

“You’ve got quite a bark. Did you learn it from some marketplace mongrel?”

“They say a master and Disciple grow alike. You sound exactly like him.”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord clicked his tongue softly and tightened his grip.

Crack-crack!

With a louder, sharper crunch, Jin Taekyung’s limp feet thrashed in the air.

Deep furrows appeared between Jeok Cheongang’s brows.

“You bastard!”

“This is my final offer. Accept it, and you can save your Disciple and preserve your martial lineage. Refuse…”

The Western Heaven Demon Lord continued in a chilling voice.

“And I will break this fellow’s neck right now, then fight you in a life-and-death duel. You will most likely be the first to fall.”

This was no empty bluff.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord knew Jeok Cheongang was not in perfect condition either.

That was only natural. He had hovered between life and death for more than a month after fighting the Blood Lord and had only just awakened.

“What will you do?”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyelids trembled.

The old master regarded his Disciple, trapped in the enemy’s grasp, with an indescribable look before opening his mouth.

“Promise me… you will keep your word.”

“Of course.”

It was, of course, a lie.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had no intention of leaving a single person alive.

Not the Sichuan Tang Clan. Not the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. Not the Divine Physician, who lay unconscious behind them in the aftermath of the battle. And…

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung. He, especially, cannot be allowed to live.

The Sword Saint’s successor was dangerous enough, but Jin Taekyung was particularly dangerous.

[1797] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

If they had fought for another half a shichen[1797]—no, even another fifteen minutes—the brat might have attained enlightenment and broken through the wall of the Supreme Peak realm.

It was a great stroke of fortune that the Demon Lord had defeated him before his enlightenment could deepen.

The Lord of Heaven is aiding me.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord barely suppressed the corners of his mouth as they tried to curl upward.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been staring at him, abruptly spoke.

“Is that enough now?”

The unexpected question made the Western Heaven Demon Lord frown.

“What are you talking about?”

“You sly bastard. You’ve become even more of a monster since I last saw you.”

“What nonsense are you—”

But the Western Heaven Demon Lord could not finish.

No, he was unable to.

Grab.

Crack-crack-crack!

Fiery pain erupted from his wrist.

The next moment, reflected in the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s widened eyes were his wrist, twisted as though a giant had wrung it, and a young man whose hand clamped around it like a hook.

“Jin Taekyuuung!”

How?

A roar filled with pain, disbelief, and shock thundered through the underground prison.

But Jin Taekyung did not hear him. Could not hear him.

His eyes were hazy, as though he were drunk, and he moved on instinct alone.

Krrrk!

Irresistible strength tore the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s wrist free as easily as uprooting a weed.

Blood fountained into the air amid searing pain.

For an instant, the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s vision went white.

Then a streak of flame bloomed before him.

“I told you.”

The old master, wreathed from head to toe in blazing hellfire, spat out each word.

“Do not touch my Disciple. Not even a hair.”

KABOOOOOM!

A massive pillar of fire surged upward.

I felt dazed.

As though I might fall asleep at any moment. Or as though I had only just woken up.

Everything felt blurred and distant.

This has to be a dream.

It definitely was.

The fact that I was alive even though I should have died long ago. The fact that Jeok Cheongang had awakened even though he should have needed several more days before he was ready to wake up.

But…

Is this a dream too?

Ding.

SYSTEM

Jeok Cheongang has awakened from a long sleep!
You have successfully completed all related chain Quests. Your noble devotion and sacrifice will be rewarded!
Level Up!
Level Up!
Level Up!
Stamina, Strength, Agility, and Internal Energy have been restored!
A total of three Level Ups has partially healed your physical injuries!

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The bright chime of bells echoed around me.

At the same time, an energy like warm sunlight spread throughout my body.

Broken bones fused together, and torn flesh healed. My damaged organs and shredded acupoints began to mend and settle back into place.

Slowly.

But steadily.

Crack.

My toes stepped on empty air.

Before I knew it, the Western Heaven Demon Lord was holding me by the throat.

My ruptured eardrums should have healed by now, but the conversation between the two men still sounded distant.

What is this feeling?

Hummm. Hummm.

A strange noise beyond description circled inside my head.

Then, in the next moment, Jeok Cheongang's voice pierced clearly into my ears.

"How long do you intend to hang there?"

I don't really know, Old Master. I just… I just can't summon any strength. I don't even know if this is a dream or reality.

I wanted to answer that familiar face, but no voice came out.

The hand pressing against my throat suddenly felt uncomfortable.

Then… I should get it off me.

By the time the thought crossed my mind, my hand had already moved.

It shot out so quickly that even I didn't realize it had moved and seized the Western Heaven Demon Lord's wrist.

Crack-crack-crack!

Hard bones crumpled, and a scream burst forth.

Without hesitation, I twisted and yanked.

Something tore, and blood fountained into the air. Before a single drop could strike the floor, a streak of flame swept past me.

"It's been a while, you reckless little brat."

The voice stretched out, carrying a hint of laughter.

Hellfire flickered from Jeok Cheongang's palm as it passed by me.

The Flame Divine Palm, mastered to its utmost limit, slammed into the chest of the Western Heaven Demon Lord as he writhed in agony.

KABOOOOOM!

A massive pillar of fire surged upward, scorching the ceiling.

The flames seemed as though they would burn forever—until ink-black Sword Force extinguished them.

Sssssssh!

"Die!"

Black clouds shrouded the Western Heaven Demon Lord's entire body.

His lips were drenched in blood, and every vessel in his eyes had burst, staining them crimson.

He looked like a madman, but the power contained within his sword seemed capable of cleaving the heavens.

Whoooooosh!

Darkness erupted from his blade, splitting the pillar of fire as it shot forward.

"Ugh."

A small groan escaped Jeok Cheongang's lips as he tried to draw up his Scorching Yang Qi.

I felt the qi crouched within his still-unrecovered body waver.

I watched it all with vacant eyes.

The darkness rushing toward me through my hazy vision.

Jeok Cheongang's swaying body.

And then—

"Ah."

A single exclamation escaped my lips.

I was here, yet at the same time, I was not.

I could feel and see everything.

Everything surrounding me felt vivid and clear.

So that was it. That was what this meant.

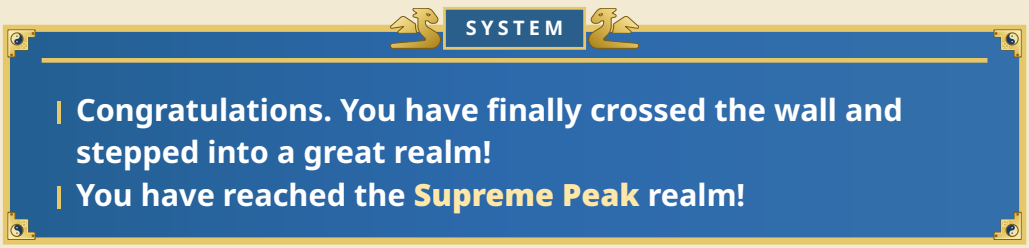
A blinding flash pierced my entire body, from the crown of my head to the tips of my toes.

Everything that had blocked my path until now cracked and collapsed.

The world that had looked hazy, as though I were drunk, cleared up. My dazed mind became as clear as a summer sky.

At the end of it all shone a light called enlightenment.

Ding.



Ding. Ding. Ding.

The bells rang louder and clearer than ever before.

I took a step.

Space vanished, and the natural qi within it surged.

I drew White Flame into my grasp with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space, and a fire dragon roared from its spearhead.

KRAAOOOOOO!

Chapter 365

So this is what it feels like.

Supreme Peak. The realm of the great martial artists chosen by heaven.

I had taken a step into a place that had always been beyond my reach, and I felt boundless freedom.

How could I put this…?

This is incredible.

A faint smile had already formed at the corners of my mouth.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

The realm of Fire Gate Divine Technique has advanced to the eighth stage.
The realm of Fire Dragon Divine Spear has advanced to the eighth stage!
Flamefire Path has advanced to…!

System notifications rang out without pause, announcing advances in my martial arts, the resulting Level Ups, and completed achievements.

Qi like molten lava surged from deep within me. I felt not the slightest fear of the darkness bearing down on Jeok Cheongang and me.

“Die!”

A scream-like shout. A face twisted like a fiend.

Nothing remained of the genial, smiling middle-aged man he had once appeared to be.

All that stood before me was a monster consumed by killing intent.

Whoooosh!

Ink-black Sword Force, wreathed in savage killing intent, came crashing down like a lightning bolt. One look was enough to feel the destructive power lurking within it.

But…

In the end, you were human too.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was already exhausted from his injuries and fatigue, and his excessive rage had scattered his mind.

When the mind wavered, so did the qi. A needle couldn’t pierce a boulder, but it could slip through the gaps between grains of sand.

Sss.

One step.

The instant my toes pushed off the ground, the space between us vanished.

I appeared in front of Jeok Cheongang, blocking his path. He shouted urgently at my back.

“You little bastard, get back—”

His voice cut off.

Cyan-white energy surged over White Flame’s transparent spearhead.

Imbued with the heat of Extreme Yang, strands of energy intertwined like tangled thread, drawing together until they finally assumed a single form.

A beautiful yet destructive concentration of internal energy. The exclusive domain of great martial artists.

Force.

I had finally made it this far.

Trembling with exhilaration, I thrust my arm toward the oncoming darkness.

Ssssh!

A single line traced through the air. Cyan-white flame shot forward like an arrow and met the darkness head-on.

Heavenly Strike.

The fire dragon’s claws tore the ink-black Force to pieces.

KRAAAAAA!

Amid the deafening roar, I saw it clearly.

The darkness scattering—and the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s face twisting with rage and shock.

The backlash from his shattered Force inflicted an Internal Injury. Blood and a furious howl burst from his mouth.

“You dare—you dare!”

“What, motherfucker?”

You’re dead now.

I beamed and kicked off the ground.

But someone else was already streaking toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord, one step ahead of me.

A small figure.

Jeok Cheongang had brought his briefly disordered qi back under control.

—You can tell me what happened later.

A short Sound Transmission followed.

—First, let’s beat the shit out of that goddamn bastard.

It was the kind of comment that made me want to hit the Like button.

Or rather, the kind of Sound Transmission.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was stunned.

How? How can this be happening?

More than a hundred years. Several jiazi[1798] of internal energy.

Everything he had built over all that time was collapsing. Being denied.

And by a mere brat in his twenties!

How is such a thing possible?

What crossed the Western Heaven Demon Lord's mind at that moment went beyond mere doubt.

Supernatural powers.

A young man barely past twenty had manifested Force. Nor was that all. He possessed the strength of a giant and the speed of the wind.

Nothing short of a ghost's intervention could explain it.

And yet…

You will be the ones who die.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord ground his teeth and planted his foot on the ground. At the same instant, a tremendous wave of qi erupted from his entire body.

"Come!"

He roared like a wounded tiger.

No—he truly was a wounded tiger.

Fatigue had accumulated over the long battle, and much of his internal energy had been exhausted. One wrist had been torn off, and one ankle was broken. A momentary misjudgment had even left him with an Internal Injury at the hands of a mere brat.

But even so, one fact remained unchanged.

"I am the Lord of Heaven's loyal servant! So long as that person is with me, even death itself shall pass me by!"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord's shout carried an almost heroic grandeur. Two voices—one old, one young—immediately followed.

"What kind of bullshit are you spouting now?"

"Sounds less like Dark Heaven and more like Darkcheonji.[1799] Hey, try saying, 'Lee Man-ui is a son of a bitch.'"

Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung.

Master and Disciple rushed forward like the wind and thrust out their arms together.

[1798] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[1799] "Darkcheonji" and "Lee Man-ui" parody Shincheonji and its founder, Lee Man-hee.

KWAANG!

A thunderous roar erupted as a terrifying wave of qi swept through the underground prison.

A moment later, blood trickled from one man's lips.

"Cough."

The Western Heaven Demon Lord staggered beneath the tremendous impact he had taken head-on.

Under normal circumstances, perhaps it would have been different. But for a man who had already suffered serious injuries, the joint attack of two Supreme Peak masters was truly threatening.

Even so, the Western Heaven Demon Lord refused to give up.

I'll bring one of them down first.

The young Disciple overflowed with strength granted by some ghostly aid, while the old Master still suffered from his injuries.

Naturally, the Western Heaven Demon Lord chose the latter.

"Die!"

His leg lashed out like a whip.

Boom!

Jeok Cheongang blocked the terrifying kick with one hand and let out a low groan.

At that very moment—

"How dare you touch him."

Crack! Crunch!

The spear shaft flashed upward like lightning and smashed into the Western Heaven Demon Lord's jaw.

His vision went white. The tremendous force, which even his Body-Protecting Qi could not fully absorb, slammed his jaws shut and severed his tongue.

Pain and impact lifted the Western Heaven Demon Lord into the air.

Waiting for him were two hands wreathed in flame.

"This old man is the Fire King, you son of a bitch!"

With that vicious curse, Jeok Cheongang unleashed the Flame Divine Palm.

BOOM!

The already unstable Body-Protecting Qi scattered. The heat of Extreme Yang seeped through the spiderweb of cracks covering the Black Dragon Armor.

A burning agony seized him, and something hot surged up his throat.

"GWAAAAAAGH!"

Black blood mixed with pieces of his organs sprayed out. Before the blood could even reach the ground, a brief sound of something cutting through the air pierced the Western Heaven Demon Lord's ears.

Ssssh-sh-sh-sh!

"…!"

Dozens of spear shadows filled his blood-red eyes, their vessels already burst.

Cyan-white flames scorched the air as they closed in from every direction. The Western Heaven Demon Lord dragged up every last shred of strength he possessed.

Ssssss!

Ink-black Sword Force surged along his blade and collided with the spear shadows.

Every clash unleashed a tremendous roar and shock wave, shaking the underground prison and churning the Western Heaven Demon Lord's insides.

"Graaagh…!"

But it wasn't over.

"Do you have time to look away?"

The cold voice sounded just as Jeok Cheongang's Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist drove into the Western Heaven Demon Lord's side.

Crack! KRRRUNCH!

It was a full-powered blow from Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King acclaimed as the greatest of the Ten Kings.

Unable to withstand the tremendous impact, part of the Black Dragon Armor shattered along with his Body-Protecting Qi. Flesh burned, and bones crumpled.

"GAAAAAH!"

A horrific scream echoed through the prison.

Even as he writhed in agony, the Western Heaven Demon Lord drew up all his remaining internal energy and unleashed it in every direction.

BOOM! KWA-KWAKWANG!

The ground, ceiling, pillars, and rocks. The manifested ink-colored Force shot out without discrimination. Everything it touched turned to dust or was sliced apart like tofu.

Yet the two people who should have been its targets had already torn through the net of Force and reached the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Shhk!

The Force gathered on the transparent spearhead slashed diagonally through the Western Heaven Demon Lord's upper body, while the two flame-wreathed palms struck his collapsing chest.

BOOM! KWAANG!

"…!"

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was hurled away like a cannonball in agony unlike anything he had ever experienced.

His body smashed through solid rock and buried itself deep within the wall.

“Ghk, ghek.”

A grotesque groan escaped him as he blinked.

Through his blurred vision, he saw two figures approaching.

Is this how I die?

The Western Heaven Demon Lord thought blankly.

For many long years, he had reigned over others as one of the strong. He had taken pleasure in trampling the weak and stealing everything they cherished.

Every ordinary martial artist in Murim contemplated death at least once.

But not the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

The only beings beneath heaven who should have been able to take his life were himself and the one supreme and exalted being—the Lord of Heaven.

And yet…

“How dare wretches such as you attempt to kill my servant?”

A voice as dry as desert sand slipped between his blood-soaked lips.

There was neither pain nor reason in the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s voice.

His eyes, now filled entirely with blood-red light, were no longer human.

Nor did they belong to the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

“This body has descended from heaven to earth. Kneel before me, from the lowest to the highest.”

At that moment, Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung shouted like thunder.

“No way…”

“The Lord of Heaven!”

Rumble-rumble!

A terrifying energy spread from the Western Heaven Demon Lord—or rather, from the being temporarily borrowing his body—and shook the ground and ceiling.

An ink-colored current writhed like a tentacle from the stump of his torn-off arm, slowly sealing the wound that had been gushing blood like a waterfall.

“Worship me. Submit before omnipotent power.”

Plop. Plop.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord’s body slowly rose to its feet.

As he approached one step at a time, manifested internal energy spread behind him like wings.

And then—

“…!”

Everything stopped.

The trembling. The wind. Even the drifting dust and the flow of the air.

Within that frozen world, a streak of darkness shot forward.

Ssssss!

The darkness approached without a sound and swallowed the two of them.

No—it would have.

Had a spearhead not thrust forward, cleaving through a flow of time divided into ever-finer instants.

Gooooooong—

Wind and qi condensed around the spearhead, then erupted.

Wreathed in cyan-white flame, the spearhead advanced, erasing everything in its path.

One Annihilation.

A blinding flash burst forth.

Time began to flow again.

With it came complete exhaustion and pain that made my entire body feel as though it were breaking apart.

I want to collapse just like this.

My arms, my legs, my fingers, every last strand of muscle—every part of my body felt ready to snap.

But I held on through sheer, superhuman strength.

Not yet. Not yet.

At the very least, I didn't want to fall before he did.

"So just fucking die already, you bastard."

I raised my head and looked at the Western Heaven Demon Lord—or rather, the thing borrowing his body.

Its entire body had been burned black, and a gaping hole had been blasted through its chest.

After inspecting the damage, the corners of its mouth slowly lifted.

"Interesting. Very interesting."

Fwoosh.

The moment it finished speaking, its fingers turned to ash and scattered.

A stray breeze swept past, and its body slowly began to crumble.

But the thing borrowing another man's body felt no pain. Instead, it tossed out a final remark with a laugh.

"We shall meet again."

I barely managed to raise my middle finger.

"Go eat a dick."

No answer came.

Beyond the drifting ash, System notifications announcing Quest success and Level Up rang out.

But the mental fatigue caused by the battle did not recover.

I only wanted to collapse right there.

No—I was already falling.

Grab.

A wrinkled hand caught me by the shoulder.

It belonged to Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King. When I saw his welcome face, I suddenly remembered something I needed to say.

“How was it?”

“What?”

“One Annihilation. It was incredible, right?”

The concern filling Jeok Cheongang’s face slowly melted away.

Then a gentle smile appeared on his lips.

“Yes. It was incredible.”

That was enough.

I closed my eyes with the answer I could no longer voice.

In the distance, the sound of the underground prison collapsing echoed faintly.

Chapter 366

Drip. Drip-drip-drip.

The world lay submerged in darkness so deep that it was impossible to tell how much time had passed.

Black clouds filled the sky, and the rain that had seemed like a passing shower showed no sign of stopping.

Within the grounds of the Sichuan Tang Clan, beside an overflowing pool of blood, corpses had piled up into a small hill.

“So? How are things inside?”

At the gates of the Sichuan Tang Clan, a black-clad man sat astride the corpse of an unknown Tang Clan martial artist. A subordinate who had just arrived from the Inner Hall answered him.

“It still isn’t over. I hear about a hundred of them remain.”

“What? That many?”

“Only half are martial artists. The rest are craftsmen who never learned martial arts, women, or children.”

“Then they should wipe them out and be done with it. What the hell are they wasting time for?”

The black-clad man’s irritation was only natural. Being stuck guarding the entrance while the others earned all the glory was bad enough, but this tedious gate duty still wasn’t over.

“Well, you see…”

“Is there some reason?”

At his superior’s frown, the subordinate hurriedly continued.

“The surviving Tang Clan martial artists are elites, for one thing. But the real problem is that they activated a mechanism array, and it’s holding everyone up.”

“A mechanism array? A poison array shouldn’t be difficult to break through.”

“It isn’t poison. It’s explosives. They had Heaven-Shaking Thunder hidden away.”

“…You don’t mean the Heaven-Shaking Thunder from Pyeokryeomun[1800], do you?”

“It seems so. Because some of them charged in carrying Heaven-Shaking Thunder and died in the explosions, quite a few of our brothers suffered serious losses.”

“Ha. Would you look at these lunatics?”

The black-clad man’s mouth fell open. He had wondered what was happening when those ominous booms began echoing through the grounds, but he had never expected the Tang Clan to possess Heaven-Shaking Thunder from the long-

[1800] Pyeokryeomun was a martial sect associated with Heaven-Shaking Thunder, a powerful gunpowder explosive.

destroyed Pyeokryeomun[1801].

He could now understand, to some extent, why the battle had been delayed.

“Wait. Then what has the Demon Lord been doing? He should have been more than capable of slaughtering them all himself.”

The black-clad man’s question reflected his unwavering faith in the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

And for good reason. The Western Heaven Demon Lord was one of the few servants permitted an audience with the exalted Lord of Heaven, and he possessed terrifying martial might.

The black-clad man had only ever heard of Heaven-Shaking Thunder and had no idea how powerful it truly was. But even the grandfather of Heaven-Shaking Thunder itself could never harm the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

“I heard he went to the Tang Clan’s underground prison a shichen[1802] ago.”

The subordinate’s answer made the black-clad man nod.

If the Demon Lord had gone there personally, he must have had a reason, and he would resolve the matter without the slightest mistake. The black-clad man felt not a trace of worry or doubt.

Nor was he alone. Everyone felt the same way.

“Then what about the First Captain?”

First Captain was the position First Fiend, the eldest of the Qilian Three Fiends, had assumed upon entering the Western Heaven Demon Lord’s service.

After a brief hesitation, the subordinate answered.

“He’s engaged in a life-and-death duel with the Sword Saint’s successor in the Inner Hall. No one has been able to approach him since one of our brothers who went to deliver news about the Heaven-Shaking Thunder lost his head.”

“…I see.”

The black-clad man said no more.

What he felt toward the Western Heaven Demon Lord was reverence and trust. What he felt toward First Fiend was fear. He had no desire to voice a careless complaint and meet a gruesome end.

“Um, Captain.”

“Do you have something to say?”

“Yes. The deputy captain asked whether we’d heard from the brothers sent to Qingcheng and Emei.”

“A message arrived just before you got here.”

[1801] Pyeokryeomun was a martial sect associated with Heaven-Shaking Thunder, a powerful gunpowder explosive.

[1802] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

The black-clad man handed him a small tube. The subordinate checked its contents, then looked up in confusion.

“This is…”

“It came from Emei.”

“Is this the only one?”

“Yes. We still haven’t heard anything from Qingcheng.”

“Their message should have arrived by now.”

“That’s true. But you know what the other captains are like.”

The three brothers of the Qilian Three Fiends resembled one another in more than their ugly appearances.

All three were cruel and eccentric fiends who lost their minds at the sight of blood.

Third Fiend, who had been assigned to Emei Sect, was somewhat better than the others. At least he had sent a messenger eagle at the appointed time.

The problem was that, according to his letter, the situation at Emei was not proceeding smoothly.

The Beggars’ Sect got involved.

The letter reported that Beggars’ Sect disciples wielding bamboo staffs and dog-beating clubs[1803] had appeared out of nowhere.

Individually, their martial arts were no match for Dark Heaven’s martial artists, but their appearance held greater significance.

They’ve already caught our scent.

The attack had been meticulously planned. The battle should have ended swiftly and decisively, yet it was dragging on.

Even with this unexpected complication, however, the black-clad man had no doubt that his side would prevail.

He had just shaken off the unease that had briefly troubled him when he suddenly looked up.

“Hmm?”

“What is it?”

“What’s that?”

At the black-clad man’s questioning voice, both the subordinate from the Inner Hall and the thirty-odd martial artists stationed at regular intervals along the walls gathered around him.

Then they saw it.

Beyond the collapsed wall, a streak of wind tore through the driving rain.

It moved swiftly enough to be called a ray of light. Then it erupted in a dazzling flash.

[1803] The dog-beating club is a weapon traditionally associated with the Beggars’ Sect in martial-arts fiction.

Ssshhhhhhk—crack!

The thirty-odd martial artists blinked. When they reflexively touched their faces, their fingers came away sticky with blood.

Slowly—very slowly—their mouths fell open and their heads turned.

In a world that seemed to have slowed to a crawl, they watched their superior collapse like a rotten old tree.

A hole the size of a fingernail had been punched through the center of his forehead.

"…!"

They felt as though they had been clubbed across the backs of their heads.

Their superior was a Peak master capable of making a name for himself anywhere under heaven. Yet a man of such skill had been killed by a strike none of them had even seen.

Before anyone present could recover from that tremendous shock, a figure sprang up onto the wall.

And then—

Ssssh-sh-sh-sh!

In the darkness, death-laden rays of light plunged down like bolts of lightning.

First Fiend was on the verge of going insane.

No—he had already been insane for more than fifty years. Now he was becoming an even greater lunatic.

"Why! Why! How could this be!"

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Blood-red Force surged from the twin axes in his hands, smashing and cleaving everything around him.

The sturdy pavilion where the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan had once resided had long since been reduced to ruins.

A lone figure darted back and forth through the wreckage.

"Ah! Eeng! Eek! Whoosh!"

Cheongpung hopped and skipped around, dodging the Force while making strange noises. First Fiend's eyes rolled white.

"You little son of a—!"

It was enough to drive him mad.

His opponent was a mere pup not yet thirty. He might have been an unprecedented monster who had received the Sword Saint's teachings and reached the Supreme Peak realm in his twenties, but even that could not erase the gulf created by age and experience.

First Fiend was an old monster from two generations back. He possessed immense internal energy, experience, and martial arts of the highest realm.

That was why, although he had been surprised at first, he had felt no real sense of danger.

The Sword Saint raised quite a monster. There was a reason the Demon Lord warned me about him before leaving. But he still has a long way to go before he can challenge this old man. Heh heh heh.

It did not take long, however, for the smile on his lips to twist into fury.

“Die! I said die!”

With a maddened roar, he swept his twin axes down through the air. A vast net of Force unfurled and descended over Cheongpung’s head.

The Red Slaughter Asura Net.

It was one of the signature techniques left behind by the Red Slaughter Demon, who had dyed the martial world in blood three hundred years ago.

That infamous Slaughter Saint, hunted throughout the Central Plains as a public enemy of Murim, had met his end in an unnamed cave in the Qilian Mountains. Three brothers hiding there from the world had discovered the martial arts manual he left behind. After mastering its contents, they had emerged anew as the Qilian Three Fiends.

And now, the perfected Red Slaughter Asura Net—a technique no one since the Red Slaughter Demon had been able to perform—had finally reappeared through First Fiend’s twin axes.

Whoooosh!

That was when Cheongpung’s gaze deepened as he watched the red net of Force close in from every direction.

Shaaah—

A cool breeze blew.

At the same time, purple Sword Force enveloped his blade and sliced diagonally through the net.

Slash!

First Fiend’s mouth fell open as Cheongpung’s One-Character Wisdom Sword dismantled the perfected Red Slaughter Asura Net with absurd ease.

“Y-You knew the Red Slaughter Demon’s martial arts?”

No perfect martial art existed.

Every martial art left by the Red Slaughter Demon deserved to be called a signature technique, but each still possessed weaknesses. Those weaknesses were secrets known only to the Qilian Three Fiends.

Yet the pup before him had identified them precisely.

“Answer me this instant!”

Cheongpung's reply was short and simple.

"What's the Red Slaughter Demon? I've never heard of him."

"…What?"

"Oh, is this about what I just did?"

Cheongpung tilted his head.

"I could just see it."

"Y-You could see it?"

"If you keep watching, you start to understand. You have more internal energy than I do, Grandpa, and your martial arts are more complicated, so it took a little longer."

"It took longer?"

"Yes. But I don't think it'll take that long anymore."

"…!"

First Fiend understood what Cheongpung meant the very next moment.

Ssssh!

A purple flash filled his vision.

Caught off guard by the sudden sword strike, First Fiend hurriedly whipped both axes through the air like lightning.

The Red Slaughter Eighteen Axes lacked subtlety, but its destructive power was second to none. Backed by more than two jiazi[1804] of internal energy, it carried enough force to split heaven and earth.

And yet—

Kagagagak!

Cheongpung's smoothly extended blade guided one axe aside, then struck the other as it swept powerfully toward his flank.

KWAANG!

A thunderous boom erupted, and First Fiend staggered. He had effectively smashed his own axes together.

Even as he retreated, he stared in stunned disbelief.

W-What in the world just happened?

Fwoosh!

Cheongpung shot toward him.

His clear eyes had grown deep and still, while sunset-purple qi surged from his sword.

Whoooooom!

First Fiend stared blankly at the strike descending toward the crown of his head.

Th-This is…

[1804] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; two jiazi are 120 years.

There was no mistaking it.

The Red Slaughter Eighteen Axes.

No—this martial art should now be called the Red Slaughter Eighteen Swords.

In less than a shichen[1805], Cheongpung had not only seen through and dismantled First Fiend's martial arts. He was making them his own.

How can this be!

First Fiend swung his twin axes with a silent cry of shock.

The revelation had slowed his reactions, but not enough to keep him from countering.

At least, that was what he believed—until Cheongpung's sword moved.

Whoooong.

The heavy, destructive sword stroke softened into the fall of a flower. Thirty-six plum blossoms bloomed from its tip and drifted down through the air.

One martial art surfaced in First Fiend's mind.

The Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords.

At the same time, he realized—

I can't avoid it.

Ssssh-sh-sh-sh!

Thirty-six plum blossoms—or rather, thirty-six streaks of Force—enveloped First Fiend's entire body.

Blood spread like mist. Slashed from head to toe, First Fiend staggered backward.

Fear filled his eyes as he stared at Cheongpung, whose sword hung loosely at his side.

"Cough. You… You are…"

"Good thing it's raining."

Cheongpung stepped forward, his voice calm.

"I don't like the smell of blood."

Splash.

Cheongpung stepped into a crimson puddle of rainwater and blood. First Fiend let out a piercing scream.

"Anyone! Is there no one out there? Hurry, get this bastard…!"

At that moment, a low voice slipped into his ear.

"Don't call out. There's no one here."

"…!"

"…!"

There had been no footsteps. No hint of anyone's presence.

And yet he was there.

[1805] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

The raindrops pouring down overhead shattered in midair before they could touch him.

“Who the hell are you—”

Slash!

First Fiend’s head flew into the air.

Cheongpung flicked the blood from his sword, then stared with a rigid expression at *him*, standing tall before him.

“I’d like to ask you the same thing. Who are you?”

His voice trembled faintly as he continued.

“Mungyeong.”

Chapter 367

The warning signs had already been there.

And there was more than enough cause.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The ground split apart, and the ceiling shook. The underground prison that had symbolized the darkness of the Sichuan Tang Clan for hundreds of years could no longer withstand the aftermath of one battle after another. It was collapsing.

Along with the countless vengeful spirits of prisoners who had died in the prison—and the three people who were still alive and well.

"…What the fucking hell is this?"

Jeok Cheongang looked around in disbelief.

He had definitely been in a forest before closing his eyes. Then he had opened them to find himself in a cave that might or might not be a prison.

And that wasn't all. He had dragged his still-ailing old body into a fight to the death with some unknown son of a bitch.

Fine. He could understand things up to that point. Jin Taekyung passing out the moment the battle ended? That was entirely possible too.

But…

"Isn't this taking things too damn far? Fuck."

It was the kind of situation that made profanity spill out on its own.

Where was this place? Who was I? Why was the ground splitting apart, and why were boulders the size of people raining down from overhead?

Overcome by a sudden wave of profound regret, Jeok Cheongang nearly ascended to immortality on the spot.

"Goddamn it."

He had no idea what was going on, but first he had to get out of there.

Once he reached that conclusion, he moved with lightning speed.

First, I need to get Taekyung… But who the hell is this old man?

Ah, hell. Whatever.

Jeok Cheongang slung the unconscious Jin Taekyung and the Divine Physician over his shoulders, then shot forward.

Sssshhhk! Boom!

A massive rock that fell from the ceiling grazed Jeok Cheongang by a hair and smashed into the ground. But that was only the beginning.

Boom! Boom! Rumble!

With every step he took, bizarre rocks came pouring down like a rain shower. The spectacle made Jeok Cheongang's flesh crawl.

One wrong move, and I could end up buried here.

This was no small cave.

If a cliff weighing tens of millions of geun[1806] came crashing down on their heads, even Jeok Cheongang could not guarantee his survival.

Especially with the lingering aftereffects of his injuries.

“Cough.”

He staggered as he raced across the fractured ground. Swallowing the blood rising in his throat, Jeok Cheongang smiled bitterly.

I’m in a sorry state.

His limbs were stiff as stone after so long without moving. He was ravenously hungry and utterly drained.

In that condition, he had fought some monstrous bastard who had crawled out of who-knew-where. Of course his body had deteriorated even further. If not for his internal energy, he would have collapsed long ago.

Rumble!

The vibrations suddenly grew even stronger. Jeok Cheongang gritted his teeth.

All right, I get it. Stop rushing me. I’ll find a way out.

There was someone he had to save. His one and only Disciple, who had become light and warmth when Jeok Cheongang wandered through cold, dark memories.

Yes. My one and only Disciple. My Disciple, without a doubt.

His grip tightened on the two men. An unknown strength seemed to surge from somewhere deep within him.

Flamefire Path.

Jeok Cheongang, who had faltered for a moment, became a streak of flame.

Whooosh!

The clash between Jin Taekyung and the Western Heaven Demon Lord had caused the underground prison to collapse, but that destruction actually helped Jeok Cheongang.

The interior had been devastated by their battle. All the walls that had once divided the underground prison into a maze had crumbled, leaving behind one vast cavern.

There!

Jeok Cheongang’s eyes flashed as he raced forward with his movement technique.

Every enclosed space had an entrance.

At the place where he felt a faint breeze blowing from somewhere, Jeok Cheongang saw the entrance to the underground prison—barely wide enough for one person to pass through.

[1806] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to about 600 g (1.32 lb).

Hurry. Hurry…!

Jeok Cheongang hurled himself forward with every ounce of strength he had.

He bounded across the heaving ground and dodged the rocks falling from overhead.

He passed the corpse of the Heavenly Power Demon, the old man lying dead as though asleep with a peaceful smile on his face, and shot farther and faster.

The time was brief, yet felt like an eternity. At last, Jeok Cheongang was about to take his final step toward the prison entrance.

"Made…!"

Rrrrumble! Krrrrrumble!

A tremor and roar equal to every deafening crash thus far combined—no, greater than all of them—erupted at once.

The ceiling collapsed.

Massive rocks that had accumulated over hundreds, perhaps thousands, of years crashed down over the entrance to the underground prison.

Then—

"Get the hell out of my way!"

An azure dragon's roar shook the underground prison as Jeok Cheongang drove his blue-white-flame-wreathed fist into the center of the falling rock.

KWAAAANG!

The superheated energy contained in the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist smashed and melted the rocks.

A roar like the sky splitting apart thundered through the cavern, followed by a sudden blast of scorching wind that swept across the underground prison.

"What in the world…?"

The middle-aged man in black who had hurried over after hearing the roar swallowed a groan at the sight before him.

Rrrrrumble!

Nature itself was collapsing. The cliff hundreds of zhang[1807] tall that loomed behind the Sichuan Tang Clan was slowly sinking into the earth.

The sight was staggering even from more than a hundred zhang[1808] away, but there was a far greater problem.

"D-Deputy Captain. That's where the Demon Lord is…"

The underground prison!

[1807] A zhang here is ten Korean ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[1808] A zhang here is ten Korean ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The middle-aged black-clad man, the deputy captain of Dark Heaven, felt a chill run down his spine at his subordinate's words.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord. If anything had happened to him…

We're all finished.

Cold sweat rolled down his forehead. He had not been this nervous even when the Sichuan Tang Clan used Heaven-Shaking Thunder.

He barked an urgent order.

"Gather every brother scattered across the grounds immediately!"

"E-Everyone? But there are still Tang Clan bastards—"

"Those bastards aren't the problem. Hurry!"

"Y-Yes, sir!"

The subordinate, frozen stiff, pulled a firework from inside his clothes and lit it. With a pop, a red streak of light burst in the air.

At the emergency signal, the black-clad men scattered throughout the Sichuan Tang Clan began converging on the area.

Within moments, well over a hundred had assembled.

"Deputy Captain. Please give us your orders."

The deputy captain wanted to smash in the skull of the man who had just spoken. The same went for their captain, First Fiend, who had yet to show so much as a hair despite the emergency signal.

Damn it.

The deputy captain's throat bobbed as he stared at the still-collapsing cliff.

The order he was about to give was tantamount to suicide. He was going to send them beneath a collapsing cliff to search for the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

But there was no other choice. He had to give the order.

"The Demon Lord is in there. As deputy captain, I will lead the way, and every last one of you will—"

Just as the deputy captain struggled to continue his command—

KABOOM!

An unidentifiable roar erupted, and the pile of rocks forming a small hill exploded outward.

The deputy captain and everyone around him saw a large figure burst up through the rubble.

"Demon Lord! The Demon Lord has emerged—!"

The shout cut off unfinished.

Crash! Thud-thud-thud!

The figure bounced a considerable distance from the cliff like a cannonball before rolling across muddy water and sludge and finally coming to a stop.

It was an old man, clutching two people larger than himself beneath his arms. Jeok Cheongang stared up at the dark, cloud-filled sky and drew a deep breath.

“Phaaah!”

Fresh air and rainwater seeped in through his nose and mouth.

The refreshing sensation felt as if it were washing even his soul clean. His internal energy was already exhausted, and his body felt as though it had been smashed to pieces, but Jeok Cheongang smiled with relief at having rescued Jin Taekyung.

Then, in the next instant, he staggeringly raised his upper body—and froze.

“…!”

A group stood a little over twenty zhang[1809] away, staring at him.

Well over a hundred men dressed in black, all holding bloodstained weapons.

Jeok Cheongang groaned under his breath.

“…Goddamn it. No matter how I look at them, they don’t seem like good people.”

A voice behind him confirmed his suspicion.

“They call themselves Dark Heaven.”

Jeok Cheongang was not startled by the unexpected voice.

He had been through every manner of hardship and had just escaped being crushed to death. He had already noticed from the change in his breathing that the unknown old man he had rescued was awake.

“I see. Dark Heaven. I knew it had to be those sons of bitches.”

After muttering a curse, Jeok Cheongang continued without turning around.

“Do you know where we are?”

“The Sichuan Tang Clan. Regrettably, it appears the battle has already been decided.”

“…This is driving me insane.”

That brief remark summed up Jeok Cheongang’s feelings.

He did not have enough time to wonder how any of this had happened.

“What’s your name?”

“Dong Feng. My name is Dong Feng.”

“Your sobriquet?”

“I am not a martial artist, so naturally I have none.”

“Your dantian was damaged. You’re not a martial artist?”

“I only learned a little because my Master would not stop pestering me. Medicine was always where my heart lay.”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyebrow twitched.

[1809] A zhang here is ten Korean ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Despite his severe injuries, the old man's calm bearing and manner of speech carried an unmistakable air of wisdom. Why did they remind Jeok Cheongang of a physician whose medical arts were said to have reached the divine realm?

"The Divine Physician?"

"I am merely an old medical apprentice of no consequence."

Jeok Cheongang let out a hollow laugh at the Divine Physician's answer. At last, he thought he understood what had happened.

"Thank you for waking an old man who was at death's door."

"You awakened on your own. Your will was simply that strong, Sir Jeok."

"I had no choice. Some reckless fool woke me up."

"That very reckless fool crossed the Central Plains to find me and begged for my help. He said he would do anything if it meant saving you, Sir Jeok."

Jeok Cheongang turned his head. Jin Taekyung lay collapsed beside him, covered in blood and mud.

"…What a foolish boy."

If he could wake the boy now, he would.

Perhaps then they could have one final conversation.

But Jin Taekyung had exhausted every last ounce of strength. He would not awaken. Jeok Cheongang knew that even without the Divine Physician telling him.

Yes. Perhaps… perhaps this is for the best.

Jeok Cheongang slowly rose to his feet. Ignoring the pain stabbing through his entire body, he addressed the Divine Physician behind him.

"Still have any strength left?"

"I did in my younger days. Before meeting my Master, I worked as a carpenter."

"That's an unusual past for the Divine Physician. What about now?"

"I am seventy years old."

"Your dantian is damaged, so it won't be easy, but squeeze out every last bit of strength you have. Run as far away as you can."

"With Young Master Jin?"

"I'm glad you understand."

After a brief silence, the Divine Physician spoke.

"Sir Jeok… You intend to throw your life away."

"Throw it away?"

A faint smile touched the corner of Jeok Cheongang's mouth. His gaze settled on the approaching men in black.

"Do you know why a flame dies out?"

Jeok Cheongang did not wait for the Divine Physician's answer.

Muddy water splashed beneath his advancing feet. At some point, the rain that had seemed as if it would never end had stopped.

His voice rang out, clear and unburdened.

“Because there is nothing left to burn. That is why it slowly dies out atop the ashes.”

Jeok Cheongang was ready to kindle his final flame.

He felt neither fear nor anger at the death striding toward him.

Only regret.

He would no longer be able to remain by his Disciple’s side.

“Take care of Taekyung for me.”

Just as Jeok Cheongang stepped forward after making that heartfelt request, the Divine Physician spoke.

“After witnessing countless births, aging, sickness, and deaths, I began to wonder. Does the underworld truly exist? If so, who is this fellow called Yama?[1810] And if I go there, will I meet the patients I failed to save?”

“…?”

“Whenever such questions troubled me, my Master would say, ‘The underworld must be full from all the people you sent ahead of you. You should ascend to the celestial realm instead and keep the immortals company.‘”

The Divine Physician looked at Jeok Cheongang and continued quietly.

“Sir Jeok. The underworld is full. Please wait a little longer.”

“…!”

At that moment, Jeok Cheongang felt as if every hair on his body had stood on end, and he raised his head.

High above, bathed in sunlight streaming between the retreating dark clouds, stood a boy.

No. Not a boy. That man is…!

Those eyes were clear and bright like a boy’s, yet the gaze itself was ancient and seasoned, betraying no emotion whatsoever.

Jeok Cheongang had seen those eyes only once, a very long time ago.

That was precisely why he could never forget the feeling they evoked.

The boy’s appearance brought someone to mind, and Jeok Cheongang cried out in shock.

“The Slaughter Saint…!”

[1810] Yama is the lord who judges the dead in Buddhist traditions.

Chapter 368

The boy—or rather, the “he” bearing the name Mungyeong—looked down at the ground below his feet.

Countless eyes stared up at him in disbelief. Among them was a familiar face.

They had met only once, long ago, but it was not difficult to recognize him.

“It has been a long time, Fire King.”

At his greeting, Fire King Jeok Cheongang’s eyes trembled violently.

“So it really was you…”

The greatest assassin under heaven. He had inspired not merely condemnation and contempt in countless martial artists, but awe. Then one day, he had vanished without a trace, never to appear again.

At least, not until moments ago.

“Why are you here…?”

“A great deal has happened. A great deal indeed. Wouldn’t you agree?”

The question was directed at an old man. He gazed at the Divine Physician—or rather, Dong Feng—with indescribable eyes before opening his lips.

“Thank goodness. I wasn’t too late.”

His voice rang out from every direction.

Six-Harmonies Voice Transmission.

A shudder ran through everyone at the unfathomable realm of martial arts displayed before them. The old physician quietly shook his head.

“You were too late.”

His next words carried a note of regret.

“Too late to turn back the years that have passed.”

“What can be done? Once water is spilled, it is not easily gathered again.”

“Do you not regret it?”

“Regret…”

At his Disciple’s words, he raised his head and looked toward the sky.

The rain that had seemed as though it would fall forever was gone, as were the dark clouds that had blotted out the sun. All that remained was the vast azure heaven.

Is this what you intended?

He posed the question to someone who might be looking down upon the mortal realm from above.

But no answer came.

Just as it never had.

What a damned thing this is.

He slowly closed his eyes. In the pitch-black darkness, memories steeped in blood and struggle flashed past.

He had been raised as an assassin and lived as one. His inborn karma was that of an assassin, so he killed—but he had been born human, and he hated killing.

That was why, near the end of the Great War that had stained the continent with blood, the aging assassin had buried his weapons and chosen to live as a physician.

But…

Had it come to this after all?

With a quiet murmur, he opened his eyes.

A boy's hands, white and soft.

Returned to Youth had transformed his flesh several years ago, but even that could not erase the scent of blood steeped into his hands.

"I lived as a physician for more than forty years. I wished to die as one."

His voice, laden with immense internal energy, struck their ears like thunder. The black-clad men staggered as though the sound had shaken their very souls.

"And yet, why have you come here?"

His killing intent made every hair stand on end. The deputy captain, frozen as he stared at the figure in the sky, spoke in a trembling voice.

"E-Even if you truly are the Slaughter Saint, this is no concern of yours."

"No concern of mine?"

He muttered the words in a low voice before throwing down the travel bag he had been holding.

Thud!

Something bounced out of the bag as it struck the ground and rolled to the deputy captain's feet.

"T-This is…"

They were the severed heads of two men. Though they belonged to different people, their bulging eyes and twisted expressions looked almost identical.

Like twins born at the same hour on the same day.

The deputy captain's gaze fixed on one of them.

"Captain!"

As the deputy captain stared in horror at First Fiend's severed head, the Slaughter Saint slowly spoke.

"One question. Was the one at Qingcheng the second or third of the Qilian Three Fiends?"

"…!"

Only then did the deputy captain understand.

Why no word had come from the Qingcheng Sect—and where the brothers who had failed to return after seeing the emergency signal had gone.

Only one path remained. The realization struck like lightning, and he unleashed a shout imbued with internal energy.

“Everyone, attack! Kill hi—”

Slash!

The deputy captain’s shout was cut short.

A breeze brushed his neck, and suddenly someone was standing behind him.

Can this truly be… the movement of a human being?

That was the last question to cross his mind.

He had failed to recognize the Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step performed by the greatest assassin under heaven—or rather, the greatest assassin in all history.

Only death awaited him.

Fwoosh!

Blood erupted from the severed neck in a fountain. A figure brushed past the collapsing body and took another step, stirring a wind heavy with the scent of blood.

Slash. Slash. Slash!

The heads of the black-clad men who had watched their superior die in a daze flew into the air.

Before the streams of blood could reach the ground, something pale and ghostlike swept through them.

“It was the life I wanted so desperately.”

Murmuring under his breath, he extended both hands. Long, slender threads streamed from his ten fingers.

Threads of Force—beautiful and destructive.

“And yet, why did you…”

Whoosh!

When his ten curved fingers slashed downward through the air, Force tore through space.

Everything that stood in its way was cut apart and split open. Shattered armor and weapons, limbs and heads, flew in every direction.

In a world brought to a standstill by blood and death, only one person moved freely.

“Did you wake me?”

Consumed by sorrow and fury, he was no longer the cheerful boy or the physician who had passed the two-character name Divine Physician down to his Disciple.

He had returned to the person he had been before earning the name Divine Physician, before meeting the young carpenter who had fallen into grief after

losing his wife and children to an epidemic, and before burying his weapons and leaving the Murim.

“The Slaughter Saint…!”

Someone screamed the name.

His eyes had sunk deeper than the abyss. He flung out both arms, and the wind—now a raging storm—swallowed more than a hundred black-clad men.

Kwaaang!

A high hill stood east of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

From there, one could see the entire Tang Clan estate at a glance. A small watchtower stood atop it, and martial artists had once taken turns standing guard.

Once.

Drip. Drip.

Drops of blood fell from the watchtower and dampened the grass. Some slid down the hill and touched someone’s hand.

Its back was deeply wrinkled, and its nails had turned green from long years spent practicing poison arts.

The hand belonged to Tang Sadok, the current Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan—the Myriad-Poison Asura.

“Cough.”

Blood sprayed from between his parched lips. His eyes, usually cold and forceful, looked ready to go out at any moment.

“Is this how it ends?”

Tang Sadok murmured faintly.

Everything was racing toward its end. His life. The glorious history of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

“Our family, built over centuries… brought down in a single day.”

Tang Sadok’s lament rang hollow. He no longer possessed the strength even to feel anger or sorrow.

His limbs crushed and his internal injuries severe, all the old Family Head could do was lean against an unknown tree and watch his clan perish.

This is my final gift to you.

The smiling face of a middle-aged man flashed before Tang Sadok’s eyes.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had not kept his promise. To him, the destruction of the Sichuan Tang Clan had been a foregone conclusion from the very beginning.

“Urgh… Blergh!”

The rage flaring within him like wildfire worsened his internal injuries. Tang Sadok vomited nearly half a gallon of blood, then gasped for breath.

"I'm sorry. I'm sorry…"

It was an apology to the ancestors of the Sichuan Tang Clan. To the innocent members of his household who had lost their lives because they had been saddled with an unworthy Family Head. And to Jin Taekyung and his companions, who had likely already met gruesome deaths at the hands of the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Of course, none of them could hear Tang Sadok's voice.

If we meet in the afterlife, I will apologize to you myself.

Just as Tang Sadok murmured those words inwardly—

Rustle.

The bushes stirred, and he sensed something approaching.

No. It was not human.

Only when the strange presence had drawn right up to him did Tang Sadok realize who it belonged to.

Hiss. Hiss.

A flicking tongue. A horned, triangular head. A pure-white snake burrowed into Tang Sadok's arms.

"Ha… hahaha."

Tang Sadok laughed weakly, both happy and hollow.

"So it was you."

Hisss.

The Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, Mimi, hissed as if answering its master. Its cold tongue licked the beard matted with blood.

"Clever creature. How did you find me all the way out here?"

Tang Sadok gazed at his pet snake through clouded eyes.

He had let Mimi loose because he was worried the snake might be injured in the melee. He had never thought they would meet again like this.

Nor had he imagined their final farewell would happen this way.

Rumble!

A tremendous roar shook the hill. The earth rose, and the branches of the trees trembled.

Tang Sadok raised his head and tried to find the source, but his failing eyesight could no longer make out what was happening.

He could infer only one thing.

Has the time come?

It was a roar on an entirely different scale from Heaven-Shaking Thunder.

At last, the destruction of the great Sichuan Tang Clan had reached his doorstep.

Tang Sadok slowly closed his eyes, then opened them again.

“Leave.”

Hiss?

The snake’s triangular snout tilted to one side.

“This old man has little time left. Neither does the Tang Clan. If you stay here, you will be caught up in this calamity as well.”

Tang Sadok was the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan. Even if the Western Heaven Demon Lord did not come himself, someone would certainly come to confirm whether he was alive or dead.

Tang Sadok could easily imagine what those vicious men would do if they saw the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake guarding its master’s side.

“So go. Hurry!”

He wanted to shout, but the voice he forced out was so thin it seemed ready to break apart.

Yet the spirit creature that had spent so many years beside Tang Sadok understood the final wish of the man who had been both its master and its friend.

Drip. Drip.

Damp drops fell onto Tang Sadok’s wrinkled hand.

Leaving behind a few tears, Mimi slithered away and disappeared, the snake’s white body gliding across the ground.

As her presence receded into the distance, a bitter smile briefly touched Tang Sadok’s lips.

“Yes. Go carefully.”

In his youth, he had roamed the battlefields. After the war, he had devoted his life to helping his father, the Poison King, rebuild the Sichuan Tang Clan.

He had always been expected to remain cold and meticulous. He had no friend with whom he could share his heart, no lover, and no child of his own blood.

Had that spiritual creature not remained by his side all those years, he could never have endured the loneliness.

From today onward, your name is Mimi. Tang Mimi.

On the day he first encountered the tiny Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, Tang Sadok had given her the Tang family name.

They shared neither blood nor even species, but Tang Mimi was a member of the Sichuan Tang Clan, recognized as such by its Family Head.

I have lost everyone, and you alone are the one I send away alive. Hahaha.

Tang Sadok let out a hollow laugh and blinked.

Through his fading senses, the roar and someone’s screams echoed faintly from below the hill.

It must have been the final struggle of those fighting to stave off the clan's destruction.

This old man is here, too. I, Tang Sadok, Family Head of the great Sichuan Tang Clan, am here! Come to me!

The cry, as if he were coughing up blood, only hovered at the tip of his tongue.

Tang Sadok felt the strength slowly drain from his entire body. His heavy eyelids sank lower, little by little.

I'm tired.

What if he simply closed his eyes and fell into a deep sleep?

If he took a short nap and awoke in the grand armchair in the Family Head's Hall, perhaps he would be able to see the familiar faces of his family.

How wonderful it would be if everything that had happened—including his father's death—were nothing more than a Butterfly Dream.[1811]

Yes. If only it were.

His trembling eyelids slowly sank shut.

No—they were just about to close.

"Mimi! Quick Attack!"

Hisssssss!

"…?"

What the hell is this bullshit?

Tang Sadok's eyes flew open.

His vision suddenly cleared, revealing a young man racing toward him and Mimi's white body shooting through the air like an arrow.

"Y-You?"

"Wow! Wild Grandpa Tang spotted!"

Tang Sadok blinked at Cheongpung, who was grinning brightly despite the blood covering his face.

"What… what is going on? How did you…?"

Cheongpung answered energetically.

"Mimi! Whirlwind!"

Whirrrrr!

If Tang Sadok had possessed even a shred of strength, he would have cursed him out.

Cheongpung and Mimi realized their mistake too late and bowed their heads.

"Ah, I'm sorry."

Hiss.

[1811] The Butterfly Dream alludes to the ancient Chinese philosopher Zhuangzi's dream that he was a butterfly, after which he wondered whether he was a man who had dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming of being a man.

"…"

Tang Sadok forgot that he had been half dead only moments ago and stared blankly at the man and snake before him. At last, he managed to speak.

"Our family… What happened to our family?"

"They all died."

"…!"

"Oh. Not the Tang Clan. I meant Dark Heaven's black-clad men."

You should have said that first!

As Tang Sadok choked on shock and fury, Cheongpung pressed a finger to his Mingmen acupoint. Warmth like a spring day seeped into his body.

"Cheongpung! True Qi Guidance!"

This bastard is going to keep this up until the very end…

Tang Sadok wanted to ask what had happened, but this time he could not resist the drowsiness washing over him.

Just before his eyelids closed, a voice as gentle as a spring breeze reached his ears.

"It's all over now. Rest easy."

It was the voice that announced the end of a day longer and darker than any other.

Chapter 369

“Search every inch of the place. If you half-ass it like you do your martial arts training, you’ll catch hell.”

“Oh, come on, Senior Brother. Anyone listening would think that was actually true. You really will say anything in front of the kids.”

“You spend every waking hour running around pleasure houses… Do I need to beat you senseless right here before you come to your senses?”

“Fine, fine. I get it.”

Even after his Senior Brother’s scolding, Hwangso’s scowl refused to budge.

He was a first-generation disciple of the Gongdao Sect, a martial sect in Sichuan. He had been called out for this mission along with around thirty second- and third-generation disciples.

Damn it. Five days of this bullshit.

Hwangso grumbled inwardly.

Born into a fairly prosperous merchant family, he had grown up wanting for nothing.

It was irritating enough that his father had forced him onto the path of a martial artist—a path that had never been part of his plans—simply because he wanted connections in the Murim. Five days of sleeping rough in the wind and dust had worn away what little patience Hwangso had left.

Whew. I heard the new courtesan at Tengwang Pavilion is an absolute beauty…

Just as Hwangso’s thoughts raced toward his favorite pleasure house—

“You brat! After everything I just said, you’re still letting your mind wander?”

“Ah, yes, I understand. I said I understand!”

Startled by his Senior Brother’s sudden, tiger-like roar, Hwangso trudged off.

His Senior Brother clicked his tongue at the sight, as if he found him hopeless.

“If you don’t want to die a senseless death, keep your wits about you. Surely you understand what kind of situation we’re in.”

“I understand perfectly. Aren’t we going through all this trouble to catch some fiend who isn’t even here?”

“What do you mean, he isn’t here?”

“You know what I mean. That Third Fiend or whatever. The bastard ran off ages ago, and we’re searching for him in completely the wrong place.”

His Senior Brother’s face stiffened at Hwangso’s sullen reply.

“Watch your words. Not since the Great Faction War has the Sichuan Murim united to cast a net over heaven and earth like this. Everything happens for a reason.”

“Who said there wasn’t a reason? I’m not deaf. I’ve heard it all already.”

Hwangso had heard why the net over heaven and earth had been cast so many times that his ears hurt.

Dark Heaven or whatever they were called had invaded and laid waste to the Tang Clan, Qingcheng, and Emei.

At the head of the attack had been a peerless fiend who had slain the Poison King and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun single-handedly. The Qilian Three Fiends, old monsters from two generations ago, and hundreds of Fiends had split into three groups and stained Sichuan's three foremost sects with blood.

And everyone in Sichuan, Hwangso included, knew how that day—now being called the Three-Gate Bloodbath—had ended.

"They defeated them for all to see, didn't they? Every fiend who could be called a leader was killed except for one, and the rest of the foot soldiers scattered and ran. Isn't it over?"

"…Whew."

His Senior Brother's lips moved as if he were about to reply, but he merely sighed.

Whatever he said would go in one ear and out the other. His Junior Brother had no interest in learning how much luck and sacrifice had gone into their victory.

The unknown master who suddenly appeared and saved Qingcheng Sect. The countless Beggars' Sect disciples and nearby martial sects who rushed to Emei's aid when it was in danger. And…

If not for *them*, who had saved the Sichuan Tang Clan from annihilation, the three illustrious sects with their long histories would have vanished from the Murim five days ago.

The Three-Gate Bloodbath had been a large-scale assault carried out with such thoroughness and suddenness that it had sent a tremendous shock through the entire orthodox martial world.

And this brat calls himself a martial artist with such shallow thinking. Even if he did join only because circumstances forced him to…

Hwangso bristled when his Senior Brother shook his head.

"What?"

"Enough. Pick ten men or so and search beyond that hill."

"Again? We've already searched that place several times over the past five days…"

"The area assigned to our sect must be searched a hundred times—a thousand, if necessary. I'll search the nearby undergrowth myself, so stop complaining and do as you're told."

His Senior Brother cut him off so firmly that Hwangso clamped his mouth shut.

I need to talk to Father and get back home as soon as possible. Seriously, why would the fiend who fled Emei show up here?

Thousands of people had been mobilized for the net over heaven and earth, and it had lived up to its name.

Most of Dark Heaven's remnants who had fled after their defeat in the Three-Gate Bloodbath had already been hunted down or captured.

Only the Third Fiend—the youngest of the Qilian Three Fiends who had attacked Emei—remained. The area assigned to the Gongdao Sect lay near Chengdu, practically the heart of Sichuan.

I heard the fiend isn't in good shape, either. Why would he walk straight into the tiger's jaws when he could head somewhere sensible like Tibet or Yunnan?

Hwangso's complaint was not entirely unreasonable.

It might be darkest beneath the lamp, but there was still no reason for a fiend branded an enemy of the Murim to break through such a dense net over heaven and earth and head toward Chengdu.

If there were even the slightest chance of that, why would I be here? The Qingcheng Daoists would have been guarding the place.

This was all because his Senior Brother was so rigid that it went beyond stubbornness and became downright suffocating.

Muttering a quiet curse, Hwangso crooked a finger at the third-generation disciples standing around blankly.

"You there, the big-nosed one. Yes, you. Everyone from you to that big-eared fellow over there. Ten of you—follow me."

What else could he do? When they told him to dig, he had to dig.

But as Hwangso left to search, with his Senior Brother's contemptuous gaze boring into his back, his head was filled with nothing but idle thoughts.

Just wait. The second this is over, I'm going straight to Tengwang Pavilion and having myself one hell of a time.

With his mind elsewhere, there was no chance of him conducting the search properly.

The third-generation disciples watched Hwangso for cues and lazily scanned their surroundings. During that sloppy search, not one of them noticed the faint traces of blood on the leaves.

Thank goodness they're all idiots. At this rate, I have nothing to worry about.

The Third Fiend let out a sigh of relief and extended one foot.

Sssshk.

His body shot forward, skimming over the leaves.

A master of considerable skill might have detected him if one were nearby, but judging by the level of everyone he had encountered so far, there was no chance of that.

They never imagined I would double back toward Chengdu.

The thrill of having completely deceived the orthodox faction lasted only a moment. Anger and killing intent surged from deep within the Third Fiend's chest.

If it hadn't been for those fucking bastards…!

Five days ago, everything had gone smoothly when he led his subordinates in the attack.

The death of the Sect Leader, the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun, and the Elders had left a tremendous gap in Emei's forces, and the Dark Heaven martial artists under the Third Fiend's command had driven straight into it like a massive harpoon.

Then, amid the brutal battle overflowing with blood and death, *they* appeared.

You worthless pieces of trash, lower than dogs!

One filthy beggar.

Hyuk Mujin, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, the right arm and little toe of the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi, Jin Taekyung, has arrived!

A young man whose name seemed to be either Right Arm or Little Toe—it was hard to tell.

Senior Sister! I'm here!

And a middle-aged nun who appeared to be a disciple of Emei Sect.

At first, even the Third Fiend had been dumbfounded by their fearless entrance.

What? Worthless pieces of trash, lower than dogs? Does this filthy beggar have a death wish? Just wait. This old man will tear you limb from limb and—

The Third Fiend approached with a contemptuous snort, only to swallow the rest of his words.

Behind the fearless young beggar, more filthy beggars than he could count were rushing forward.

A veritable wave of beggars!

B-Beggars' Sect?

The response had come far too quickly for the Third Fiend.

Not even half a day had passed, yet more than a thousand Beggars' Sect disciples—not dozens, not even a hundred—had assembled and rushed to Emei's aid.

The Successor Beggar commands you! Beat those dogshit bastards to death like dogs!

Armor! They're wearing armor!

Hit the exposed parts! Crush their balls!

An Emei nun charged them head-on without regard for her life, while countless Beggars' Sect disciples surged in endlessly from behind.

The Third Fiend and the black-clad men under his command fought like mad, cutting down enemy after enemy, but the tide of battle had already begun to turn against them.

Brothers of the Beggars' Sect! Never retreat!

Waaah!

"Avenge Gaettong[1812]!"

The sheer force of their human-wave assault was horrifying.

Cut down one beggar, and two did not rush forward in his place. Five or ten did.

And if he dredged up every last ounce of strength and cut them down too? There was no need to worry about what came next. A club flying in from somewhere would smash his balls while an iron staff cracked the back of his skull.

The dead had no future.

Guh…!

Like a body slowly soaked through by drizzle, the black-clad men collapsed one after another as cold corpses.

Even the Third Fiend, who should have turned the tide of battle, had no time to look after his subordinates.

Form the Demon-Subduing Dragon-Taming Formation!

The Seven Fairies, Emei Sect's finest masters, used a combined formation to bind the Third Fiend's feet.

Even when seriously wounded, they never retreated. They attacked as if their lives meant nothing, and the Third Fiend gradually grew exhausted from the mounting fatigue and anxiety.

The Third Fiend's face twisted violently as he recalled what had happened five days earlier.

And then Extinction Divine Nun appeared. That damned old monster brought it all to an end.

The arrival of Extinction Divine Nun shocked not only the Third Fiend but even the disciples of Emei.

Thirty years ago, at the age of one hundred, she had withdrawn from worldly affairs. She was the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun's only Senior Aunt, and everyone believed she had since died.

When another Supreme Peak master suddenly appeared, the Third Fiend chose to flee without a moment's hesitation. The black-clad men under his command scattered and ran after their superior.

It had been an undeniable defeat.

Yet the Third Fiend had survived to the bitter end.

[1812] *Gaettong* is a Korean nickname meaning "dog dung."

He had concealed himself with a human-skin mask and a disguise technique, found the weakest point in the net over heaven and earth, and made his way here.

To this nameless cliff where no one had set foot.

“At last… Guh!”

As the cliff rapidly drew closer, the Third Fiend suppressed the emotions welling up inside him.

Only now did the grief and fury of losing his only blood relatives strike him all at once.

“Do not feel too aggrieved. Though I must retreat for now, this youngest brother will surely avenge you, my elder brothers.”

The Third Fiend had just sworn his vengeance and reached toward the cliff when —

Shhk!

His eyes flew wide.

A searing sensation, like a burn, blazed through him as his hand fell away at the wrist.

It was agony he had not felt in a very long time. A beat later, a scream burst from his cracked lips.

“Kyaaaaargh!”

At the same time, a chill raced down his spine.

He pressed his acupoints like lightning to stop the bleeding, then jerked his head up.

Where part of the solid cliff face had stood only moments before, there was now an all-too-familiar face.

“B-Big Brother?”

The Third Fiend’s cry held both delight and shock.

But First Fiend’s response was calm.

“So it seems. Your disguise technique was so poor that I suspected as much.”

“…!”

Crack. Crackle.

At that moment, First Fiend’s hideous face rippled like a wave. His hunched back straightened, and his arms and legs grew long and slender.

In the place of the ugly old man now stood a handsome boy.

“Who the hell are you?”

At the Third Fiend’s shout, a faint smile crossed the boy’s impassive face—the face of the Slaughter Saint.

“Mungyeong.”

A faint smile crossed the boy’s impassive face—the face of the Slaughter Saint.

“Your enemy.”

Chapter 370

The Sichuan Tang Clan had always been famous for its reclusive ways.

Even prominent figures could not easily pass through its gates. Fearing that daughters who married out might reveal the clan's martial arts and secrets, the Tangs instead brought in sons-in-law and had them take the Tang surname.

The gates of the Sichuan Tang Clan, which had endured for hundreds of years in this manner, had been thrown wide open only seven days ago.

"Over there! Get that pillar straight!"

"Pull on three. Ready. One, two—!"

Burly laborers hauled on ropes and carried stone and lumber across the grounds.

Buildings were slowly taking shape over foundation stones still stained dark red with blood.

Farther away, dozens of Buddhist nuns had gathered to chant prayers.

"May I have no other thought at the end of this life, with Amitabha[1813] alone beside me, my heart forever bound to the light from the white curl between his brows…"

The nuns, their heads shaved close and their eyes filled with spiritual energy, were from Emei Sect.

Before them, countless wooden coffins burned amid roaring flames.

"May you be reborn in the Pure Land. We will never forget your steadfast devotion or your souls."

Several days and nights had passed, yet the fires still had not gone out.

That was how many lives had been lost in the Three-Gate Bloodbath. The Sichuan Tang Clan, in particular, had suffered catastrophic casualties.

"Whew…"

"Venerable Myoryeong, you look exhausted. Perhaps you should rest, even if only for a little while…"

"No, Daoist Myeongjin. I am merely doing what must be done, so please do not concern yourself. Let us continue."

The Daoist studied the middle-aged nun's pale face, then nodded gravely.

A short while later, martial artists with swords at their waists approached in a line, carrying several dozen wooden coffins.

Among them were Daoists of Qingcheng Sect, disciples from small and mid-sized sects, and beggars streaked with grime.

A group of physicians came running along behind them.

"The patient suddenly started vomiting blood? Weren't they stable?"

[1813] Amitabha is a Buddha associated with rebirth in the Pure Land.

“If I knew that, would I be here right now? The patient clearly suffered serious internal injuries, but I can’t make sense of these symptoms…”

“Spread out and bring the Divine Physician! Quickly!”

Emei nuns, Qingcheng Daoists, Beggars’ Sect beggars, and martial artists dispatched from sects both great and small. Alongside them were ordinary people—carpenters, stonemasons, physicians, and more.

Countless people moved through the grounds of the Sichuan Tang Clan, each diligently carrying out their own task.

From a tall pavilion, a young beggar watched the scene through an open window and muttered wearily.

“I never thought I’d live to see something like this. And in the Sichuan Tang Clan, no less.”

Hyuk Mujin, lying on a bed, answered him.

“Stop watching and go help. Don’t slack off just because you’re the Successor Beggar.”

“Slack off?”

Gung Gibang’s eyes widened as he pointed at himself.

His upper body was tightly wrapped in spotless white bandages, and one leg had been fitted with a makeshift splint. They were glorious wounds earned in battle against the Third Fiend.

“You can look at me and still say that? You call this slacking off? Huh?”

“Are you the only one who got hurt?”

Hyuk Mujin snorted, then deliberately wriggled like an earthworm.

Unlike Gung Gibang, he was wrapped in bandages from head to toe, making him look like a mummy.

“You have to get hurt this badly before people say, ‘Ah, this kid must have had a rough time.‘ You understand?”

“…!”

Gung Gibang trembled.

The fact that his wounds were less severe clearly proved that his martial arts were superior, yet somehow, he felt as though he had lost.

“I had my bandages changed five times!”

“I’m lucky to be alive. Besides, wasn’t that because you were so filthy? I heard a physician tried to scrub you clean, then passed out from exhaustion. Is that true?”

“…”

“Forget it. Talking to you any longer will only subject me to more bad breath. Since we’re on the subject, ask them to brush your teeth next time, too. Every time I talk to you, I feel like I’m speaking into a street mutt’s ass.”

What a vicious tongue.

Gung Gibang was speechless for a moment. Then he stared at the ceiling and lamented.

“The Third Fiend should have killed that bastard.”

“Hey. That’s crossing a line.”

“I still don’t understand how someone like you survived that battle.”

“If you’re really that curious, try following our Captain around for two years.”

“…I’ll pass.”

For all their constant bickering, there was one thing Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin agreed on: Jin Taekyung.

He seemed to embody every upheaval under heaven. He possessed the tenacious vitality and sheer determination to survive any crisis.

And now, Jin Taekyung had reached such distant heights in martial prowess that they could scarcely believe he was human like them.

There is one more person like that.

Yeah. That guy.

The same thought crossed both their minds, and their heads turned in unison.

“Mimi, Whirlwind!”

Whirrrr!

“Good job, Mimi! Now fly through the air!”

Hiss?

“Oh. You can’t do that. Then this time…”

Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang wondered whether the bizarre young man ordering a snake to fly could truly be the Huashan Divine Dragon—the Sword Saint’s successor who had single-handedly defeated First Fiend, the strongest of the Qilian Three Fiends.

“Say, Gung.”

“What?”

“Do you have to be a little unhinged to become a Supreme Peak master?”

“…I don’t know. I really don’t know anymore.”

Gung Gibang avoided the question.

His own master was rather eccentric, but nowhere near as strange as Jin Taekyung or Cheongpung.

Then again, judging by the Sword Saint and the Fire King, perhaps disciples really did take after their masters.

“But what exactly is that snake?”

“A snake with horns that large? Other than an imugi,[1814] there’s only one possibility. A Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake.”

[1814] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent often depicted as a dragon that has not yet attained its full form.

“When I was young, I read an encyclopedia of spiritual creatures that described it as a massive, pitch-black venomous beast.”

Cheongpung shouted.

“Mimi! Lie down!”

Hiss!

“Looking at it now, it doesn’t seem like a venomous beast. It just looks like an ordinary animal.”

“That’s what I’m saying.”

“But why is Cheongpung here? He was barely injured.”

“Didn’t you hear that loud crash outside earlier? They say Cheongpung went out to help and ended up destroying a pavilion.”

“…Oh.”

Both men fell silent. Lying side by side on their beds, they stared up at the ceiling.

Nearly ninety percent of the clan’s buildings had been damaged, but this pavilion had somehow retained its shape. It was now serving as a temporary clinic for the most important patients.

Catching the scent of medicinal decoctions drifting in from somewhere, Hyuk Mujin suddenly murmured,

“It feels like a dream.”

“Tell me about it.”

Seven days had passed since the Three-Gate Bloodbath.

Sichuan’s Murim had united to cast a net over heaven and earth. Most of Dark Heaven’s black-clad men, who had stained every corner of Sichuan with blood, had either been killed or captured. Even the Third Fiend, who had vanished without a trace, had been seized by a mysterious figure.

And with that, the brief war had come to an end.

But…

“I don’t think this is over. What do you think, Gung?”

“Do you even have to ask? If this is really the end, I’ll sear my own palm.”

They were hardly the only ones who sensed the looming danger.

In barely two months, Henan and Sichuan had been stained with blood.

Once news of the Three-Gate Bloodbath spread to the farthest reaches of the continent, everyone under heaven would realize the truth.

The dark cloud called Dark Heaven had already reached their doorstep.

An undeniable age of turmoil was beginning—and heroes were born in such times.

Hyuk Mujin’s gaze naturally turned toward the closed door.

“When do you think our Captain will wake up?”

“Who knows? Do I look like I have an answer? Mungyeong says there’s nothing wrong with him, so all we can do is wait.”

“Speaking of which, Mungyeong may be skilled for his age, but isn’t he a little young for us to entrust the Captain to him?”

“The Divine Physician is busy, I suppose. Great Hero Jeok is still recovering his strength, and there are far too many critical patients, including Great Hero Tang Sadok. There’s no helping it.”

“I understand. I do. But even if he is the Divine Physician’s Disciple, Mungyeong is still… What could a child that young possibly know?”

At Hyuk Mujin’s worried words, Cheongpung’s head snapped up.

“Uh-oh. Don’t say that. You’ll die.”

“Young Hero Cheongpung?”

“What you just said—don’t say it in front of Grandpa Mun. I mean, especially not in front of Mungyeong.”

“What? Why would you suddenly say that?”

“Don’t. Really, don’t.”

“…?”

Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang exchanged bewildered looks.

Then Cheongpung suddenly gasped.

“Mimi! Where did you go, Mimi?”

Cheongpung desperately searched for the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake that had vanished the moment he looked away.

Just then, a strangled shout erupted from beyond the tightly closed door.

“Ghk! You damn snake!”

The three men’s gazes collided in midair.

At the same time, several voices calling one person’s name rang out all the way outside the pavilion.

“Benefactor!”

“Captain!”

“Jin Taekyung!”

The shout sent the people working outside into an uproar.

“Did you hear that?”

“Could he have woken up?”

“Tell the Sect Leader! Hurry!”

I had a nightmare.

In pitch-black darkness where I couldn't see an inch ahead, a snake was slowly tightening around my neck.

I couldn't breathe. My vision turned white.

Then I opened my eyes and expelled the breath trapped in my lungs.

"Ghk!"

Hiss.

"…?"

Hiss? What the fuck?

My brain stopped working for three seconds.

At last, I realized what my nightmare had been. I grabbed the horn of the snake coiled tightly around my neck.

"You damn snake!"

I didn't care whether it was called a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake or Mimi-chan. Starting today, this bastard's name was Snake Wine.

"You're living on dew from now on. Chamisul."[1815]

I was about to whirl it around and slam it into the floor when the tightly closed door shattered and someone burst into the room.

"Benefactor!"

Cheongpung's thunderous shout made my skull ring.

Behind him, Hyuk Mujin came wriggling like an earthworm while Gung Gibang hopped in on one leg.

"Captain!"

"Jin Taekyung!"

"…Why do you two look like that?"

Hyuk Mujin bounced his body vigorously and answered.

"The Third Fiend. That crazy old monster did this to me."

Gung Gibang helpfully elaborated.

"It's a miracle he survived. That lunatic Hyuk Mujin threw dirt and rocks at the Third Fiend. If the Seven Fairies hadn't stepped in to protect him, he would have been torn limb from limb."

"…?"

Who the hell was the Third Fiend, and who were the Seven Fairies? Kim Seonja was my high school disciplinarian's name…[1816]

These lunatics.

My relief at surviving the underground prison lasted only a moment. A headache came on, and I pressed a hand to my forehead.

[1815] Chamisul is a Korean soju brand whose name literally means "true dew."

[1816] In Korean, *chil seonja* ("Seven Fairies") shares *seonja* with the personal name in "Kim Seonja," prompting the narrator's association.

I had clearly told them to stay put at the Divine Physician's residence, but apparently they hadn't been able to resist crawling out and fighting to the death.

Thank goodness they had survived. What would have happened if they had died?

"Were you two that desperate to die? What kind of trouble did you cause this time?"

"…?"

"…?"

"What? Why are you looking at me like that?"

The three of us—everyone except Cheongpung—exchanged bewildered looks.

"Is there a problem?"

"Of course there is."

"You told us to go save Emei Sect, Captain."

The first answer came from Gung Gibang. The second came from Hyuk Mujin.

They were both talking nonsense, so I deliberately frowned.

"What are you talking about? I did?"

"Yes. That's what Mungyeong told us. Did you hit your head?"

That couldn't be it.

I had felt it the instant I opened my eyes. Powerful qi boiled throughout my entire body.

Everything within my sight, along with the energy of nature surrounding me, felt clear and vivid.

So this is Supreme Peak…

I wanted to test this power immediately. Not to mention the System messages that must have piled up like a mountain by now.

But before listening to any more of this nonsense, there was one thing I needed to ask.

"Is everyone all right?"

They knew who I meant by *everyone*.

Instead of answering, Cheongpung threw open the enormous window.

"See for yourself, Benefactor."

As if in a trance, I slowly walked toward the window.

A warm spring breeze brushed across my face. An oddly quiet atmosphere greeted me as I leaned my head out beyond the window.

"Ah."

I looked down and found myself speechless.

There were people below.

Nuns, Daoists, craftsmen who appeared to be carpenters, and physicians dressed in spotless white robes. Countless eyes were fixed upon me, all filled with the same emotion.

Awe.

The next moment, they paid their respects as though they had made an agreement beforehand.

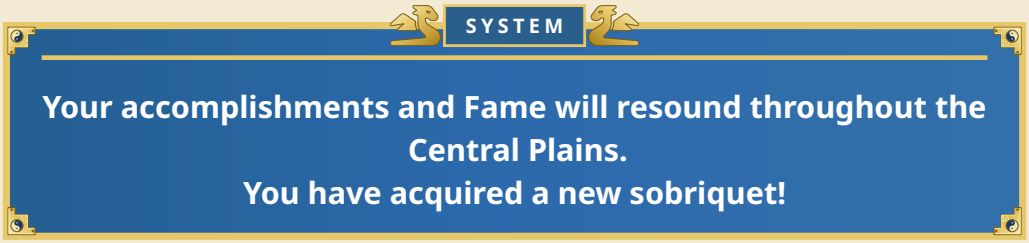
Some formed a fist-and-palm salute. Some bowed their heads slightly. Others prostrated themselves and bowed deeply.

Then a vast chorus rose as one.

“We pay our respects to the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

A shudder ran through me from the crown of my head to the tips of my toes.

Ding.



As the System alert rang in my ears, I spotted someone in the distance.

“Well done.”

I smiled back at Jeok Cheongang.

Chapter 371

“We pay our respects to Great Hero Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

When that awe-filled cry rang throughout the grounds of the Sichuan Tang Clan, Jin Taekyung was not the only one who felt a shiver run through him.

Watching from a distance, his old master had to struggle to contain the emotion welling up inside him.

You rascal…

Jeok Cheongang remembered the day he had first met Jin Taekyung as clearly as if it were yesterday.

The Third Young Master of a frontier martial family. The young man who had only just begun making a name for himself in Shanxi had become a Hidden Dragon, and now, at last, he was spreading his wings and soaring into the blue sky.

Yes. You truly are a Divine Dragon—and a Great Hero.

Their eyes met, and Jin Taekyung grinned. Leaning halfway out the window, he waved both hands wildly.

“What’s my name?”

“Jin Taekyung!”

“And my sobriquet?”

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

“Louder—!”

“Waaaaaaaah!”

The solemn gathering erupted into a frenzy, and Jeok Cheongang finally burst into the laughter he had been holding back.

“Ha! Ha-ha-ha!”

His hearty laughter mingled with the cheers. The breeze was cool, and the sky was clear.

It was the dawn of an age of turmoil, but the day a new hero was born was warm with spring.

Jeok Cheongang appeared shortly after the frenzy died down.

“You’ve packed quite a crowd into this millet-sized room.”

“Huh? It’s not cramped at all.”

“Great Hero Jeok, there’s an empty seat over there.”

Unlike Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin, who could die and come back without ever learning to read the room, Gung Gibang was a pure-blooded beggar to his very bones. He moved at once.

“Oh my, now that you mention it, this place is practically bursting at the seams. I’ll wait outside.”

Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin waved at him.

“Goodbye, Gung Gibang.”

“He’s finally leaving. Captain, haven’t you smelled a stray dog’s ass around here for a while now?”

I nodded cautiously.

“Yeah. It was pretty strong…”

“Stop talking shit and get out, both of you!”

“No, I’m telling you, it really did smell…”

“All right. Don’t get so angry, Gung Gibang.”

Cheongpung lowered his head dejectedly at Gung Gibang’s furious outburst.

“Mimi. Say goodbye with a whirlwind.”

Hiss. Hissss!

“…What the fuck.”

Looks like Mimi had picked up some new tricks in the meantime. After putting on that flashy performance, Cheongpung was the last to leave the room.

Jeok Cheongang finally spoke.

“You reckless little brat. You certainly made quite a ruckus.”

His face was stern, his voice low and subdued.

He really hadn’t changed at all. Seeing Jeok Cheongang act just like his usual self made me want to laugh for some reason.

“You laughing?”

“Of course I’m laughing. What else should I do, cry?”

“Hah, look at this brat. You made a spectacle of yourself in front of everyone and dragged our sect’s reputation through the mud, yet you still have the nerve to say that?”

“You were laughing pretty loudly for someone who thought that.”

“…!”

“I saw everything.”

The stern expression he had been struggling to maintain collapsed all at once. Jeok Cheongang’s head slowly turned toward the window.

“Ahem. What exactly do you claim to have seen?”

“About fifty people besides me probably saw it too. For a moment, I thought your smile had split your mouth open and you were bleeding from the corners.”

He'd practically looked like the Chinese Joker.

My finishing shot left him no room to escape. Jeok Cheongang hesitated for a long while, unable to continue, before finally muttering one word.

"…Did."

"Huh?"

"I said you did well!"

Jeok Cheongang shouted, his face bright red, then grumbled under his breath.

My smile deepened at the sight.

Yes. That one sentence was enough.

"Thank you. It was all thanks to you, Old Master."

"…"

What was this? His expression seemed strangely off.

His eyes even looked almost hurt. I asked, baffled,

"What's wrong this time?"

"Nothing. It's nothing."

"Your face doesn't exactly say nothing…"

"I said it was nothing!"

"Why are you shouting? The mood was finally warm and pleasant for once."

"If I say it's nothing, then take it as nothing! You keep prying and asking questions, so this is happening!"

"Uh-oh. It's getting worse?"

What was wrong with this man all of a sudden? Had I screwed something up?

I was tilting my head in confusion when—

Rustle.

Two presences were coming up the stairs.

Their footsteps were so light and graceful that I might never have noticed them if my senses hadn't grown even sharper after crossing the threshold.

They're both incredible masters.

Two Supreme Peak masters, just like that?

After all the crises I had weathered lately, my body moved on its own.

But as I clenched my fists, Jeok Cheongang stopped me with a glance and waved one hand.

A thin stream of hot air gently pushed open the closed door.

"You're all so impatient. Couldn't even wait fifteen minutes before swarming up here?"

An old Buddhist nun and a Daoist answered Jeok Cheongang's gruff voice in turn.

"Impatient? Hearing that from a lay devotee gives this poor nun a rather strange feeling."

“This junior was discourteous. However, given the circumstances…”

The elderly nun, her face covered in fine wrinkles, was a stranger to me. But I immediately recognized the Daoist.

I cupped my hands toward him.

“Greetings, Perfected One.”

“It’s good to see you again, Fellow Daoist Jin.”

The old Daoist was Cheongpung the Ancient Sword, the Sect Leader of the Qingcheng Sect whom I had once visited to ask for help finding the Divine Physician.

Then this nun must be Emei Sect’s new Sect Leader… Who is she?

I knew a fair amount about famous masters by now, but not enough to understand the inner workings of every sect.

Especially when it came to a Sect Leader who had only recently taken office after the death of the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun.

As if he had read my thoughts, Jeok Cheongang quietly sent me a Sound Transmission.

That old hag is Emei Sect’s Extinction Divine Nun. She may look kindly, but once she loses her temper, she becomes a rakshasa[1817] incarnate. Watch your mouth around her. And whatever you do, don’t mention her age.

I replied cautiously through Sound Transmission.

Just how old is she?

Older than this old man. She was also the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun’s Senior Aunt.

Oh.

I didn’t know Jeok Cheongang’s exact age, but I knew he was over a hundred. Add the sheer force of that sobriquet…

I bowed deeply to the ancient woman who looked like the matriarch of a bossam restaurant.[1818]

“Greetings! My name is Jin Taekyung!”

“Good to meet you, Benefactor Jin.”

The Extinction Divine Nun studied me with a strange look in her eyes, then nodded.

“So the rumors were true. No—they fell short.”

Cheongpung the Ancient Sword smiled faintly.

“Isn’t it truly astonishing?”

[1817] A rakshasa is a demon or fearsome spirit in South Asian and Buddhist traditions.

[1818] Bossam is boiled pork commonly wrapped in salted napa cabbage and served with condiments; a bossam restaurant matriarch evokes the familiar image of an elderly Korean neighborhood restaurateur.

“The waves behind drive the waves ahead on the Yangtze. It seems the younger generation means to sweep even old people like us aside. To cross the threshold at such a young age…”

“It isn’t only him, Venerable Nun. There is also a young man named Cheongpung.”

“Ah, the Sword Saint’s successor?”

“Yes. This poor Daoist lacks the discernment to judge which of the two is superior, but both young men are unquestionably heaven-sent. They are a great blessing to the Murim.”

“Oh…”

Interest and surprise flickered across their weary faces.

I was shifting my eyes awkwardly when Jeok Cheongang stepped in front of me.

Not that it accomplished much, considering the difference in our heights.

“You’ll wear the boy’s face out staring at him. Say what you came to say and hurry along.”

The two Sect Leaders looked embarrassed by his blunt words and finally got to the point.

“A problem has arisen. Could the two of you accompany us for a while?”

“It won’t take long. You have my word.”

“Accompany you? Right now?”

Jeok Cheongang asked in a displeased voice as he turned toward me.

“What will you do?”

“…”

Two Sect Leaders from the Nine Sects and One Gang were asking for my help. What exactly was I supposed to do?

“I’ll go.”

My body felt light, and accompanying them would give me a chance to hear everything that had happened. There was no real reason to refuse.

At my ready answer, the two Sect Leaders took the lead.

Then Jeok Cheongang abruptly asked,

“But where’s the other one?”

“He’s waiting below.”

“He said he preferred not to attract anyone else’s attention.”

The other one? If he was important enough to join this group, was it Tang Sadok, the Family Head of the Tang Clan?

Well, whoever it is, I’ll see him soon enough.

But my curiosity vanished the moment we left the pavilion and encountered a familiar face.

A delighted shout burst from me.

“Hey, you little punk! Mungyeong!”

Mungyeong looked exactly as he had before leaving the Sichuan Tang Clan.

Dark Heaven had invaded not long after he left, so I had been worried. Yet, perhaps our paths had simply missed each other, because he had somehow escaped without a scratch.

“When did you get here? You look taller than before. Going through a growth spurt?”

“…”

“Why so quiet? Are you in a bad mood? Maybe…”

I ruffled Mungyeong’s hair, then leaned closer and whispered,

“Did you have a wet dream this morning?”

“…!”

“You did. You totally did.”

Look at the little brat. Too embarrassed to say a word.

I smiled with satisfaction.

That sort of thing happened from time to time at his age. Maybe this was my chance to spread proper sex education throughout this dusty old Murim.

“Your hyung[1819] here is going to show you a whole new world. From now on, call me Teacher Jin Seong-ae.”[1820]

Teacher Gu Seong-ae, are you watching? Your knowledge is crossing space and time to reach the next generation.

I was proudly patting Mungyeong on the shoulder when—

“Uh…”

“Um…”

“Oh dear… We forgot to tell him.”

Forgot to tell me what?

Three long sighs sounded behind me. At the same time, Mungyeong spoke in a flat voice.

“Take your hand off.”

“…Huh?”

“And I stopped having wet dreams a long time ago.”

“That’s a little problematic, because your secondary sexual development hasn’t completely finished ye—no, that’s not what I mean.”

I swallowed hard.

A terrifying possibility had just flashed through my mind.

“Who… are you?”

[1819] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger male uses for an older brother or older male companion. Taekyung uses it to refer to himself as Mungyeong’s senior.

[1820] Gu Seong-ae is a Korean sex educator. Taekyung parodies her name by replacing Gu with Jin.

Mom, I’m scared.

“…And that is how things came to this.”

“It truly is a bizarre matter.”

Even as the two Sect Leaders raced along using their movement techniques, their voices never wavered.

They looked at me, waiting for an answer. I forced my lips apart.

“Ah, right. So there’s some kind of strange formation where we’re going?”

“According to the Third Fiend, whom we captured and interrogated, that appears to be the case. But the formation itself is so strange…”

Jeok Cheongang answered gruffly.

“This old man and this brat are both hopeless when it comes to formations. Looking at it won’t tell us a damned thing.”

I agreed. The Fire Gate Cavern on Mount Jiuhua contained an extraordinary Mystic Gate Formation, but that didn’t make either of us experts.

We’d be better off calling someone from the Zhuge Clan.

But it would take the Zhuge Clan a considerable amount of time to get here.

For some reason, the two Sect Leaders seemed to have high expectations of us.

Especially me.

“Fellow Daoist Jin, did you notice anything else strange about that man? Anything in his words or behavior?”

“I’ve told you everything. And from what I could tell… I don’t think it was possible for him to get any stranger.”

Dark Heaven was strange by nature. They were fanatics who worshiped the Lord of Heaven as almost—no, simply—as a god.

The Blood Lord and the Western Heaven Demon Lord were no different, with all their bizarre powers and abilities.

One regenerated like a human Troll. Another popped his arm off and stuck it back on like he had double-sided tape under it. And then there was the possession at the end.

The more I thought about it, the more miraculous our victory seemed.

We had fought those lunatics and somehow won.

“Before you awoke, Benefactor Jeok gave us a general account of what happened. Once the messenger eagle we sent to Henan returns with a reply, we should have a clearer idea of how to proceed.”

“If you notice anything strange when you examine the formation, tell us.”

“Yes.”

As I answered, I glanced at the figure racing far ahead of us.

Mungyeong.

No—the man known as the Slaughter Saint.

Fuck. What the hell is the Slaughter Saint doing here?

Honestly, I had nearly pissed myself.

Even if I spent half a day swimming in the Sanzu River valley, grilled meat, and came back, it wouldn't be this bad.[1821]

Mungyeong was the Slaughter Saint. And I asked the Slaughter Saint if he'd had a wet dream!

Teacher Gu Seong-ae, I nearly died because of you.

I had just let out a private sigh of relief when the dense undergrowth around us fell away, revealing towering cliffs ahead.

[1821] In Buddhist tradition, the Sanzu River marks the boundary between life and death.

Chapter 372

“This is the place.”

“It’s a cliff, isn’t it? A pretty ordinary one.”

I stopped with the others before the steep cliff and looked around.

It rose over a hundred zhang,[1822] a sheer wall of solid rock, but there was nothing particularly remarkable about it.

There’s supposed to be a formation here?

It didn’t take long to find the answer.

Following a sudden sense of déjà vu, I walked slowly forward and stopped before a yellowish-brown section of the cliff face.

“This is…”

Everything has a flow and a grain. Even something as invisible and intangible as qi is no exception.

And the senses I had gained upon reaching the Supreme Peak realm were more than sharp enough to detect the unnatural flow of qi.

“A formation?”

A voice answered my mutter.

“More precisely, an illusion formation.”

Mungyeong—or rather, the Slaughter Saint—gave me a dry look, then stepped forward and extended a hand.

An enormous amount of qi stirred. The solid rock face vanished like mist, revealing the mouth of a pitch-black cavern.

“Your eyes aren’t completely useless, at least.”

“Uh, what?”

“Don’t ask again.”

The Slaughter Saint tossed out those words and headed into the cavern without giving me a chance to respond.

Was that an insult or a compliment?

It left me feeling strangely annoyed.

Still, it would have been awkward to get angry. I sensed no hostility toward me in the Slaughter Saint’s words or actions. He was merely as dry and stiff with me as he was with everyone else.

That made it more embarrassing than infuriating.

“…”

Of course, the fact that he was the Slaughter Saint also had something to do with my willingness to let it slide.

[1822] A *zhang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred zhang is about 303 m (994 ft).

If that was how the Slaughter Saint talked, what was I supposed to do? Even if it rubbed me the wrong way, I had to put up with it.

I should be grateful I was still standing after bringing up wet dreams.

I nearly turned the Slaughter Saint into the Rice Saint, so this is practically getting off easy.[1823]

As I had that thought, I heard a low chuckle beside me. I turned to find the corners of Jeok Cheongang's mouth twitching.

"Why are you laughing all of a sudden?"

"No reason. I was just thinking that the Slaughter Saint is remarkably incapable of being honest."

"What?"

"Don't ask again."

"…"

What was this? Some new catchphrase?

Jeok Cheongang strode off. The two Sect Leaders and I followed him into the dark cavern.

Still…

I couldn't believe a place like this had been hidden here.

It was even close enough to reach within half a day from Chengdu, the heart of Sichuan. That was half a day at an ordinary commoner's pace. For anyone trained in martial arts, it would take far less time.

I looked around as we made our way through the seemingly endless cavern.

Even the entrance is huge. Several times larger than the Sichuan Tang Clan's underground prison.

I had heard a brief explanation on the way here. The murderous criminals of Dark Heaven had stayed in this very cavern.

So this was where they had hidden while waiting for the right moment. That explained where so many of them had come from.

But how did they get in here to begin with?

More than three hundred enemies had attacked the Tang Clan under the Western Heaven Demon Lord's command.

Add in the men sent to Qingcheng and Emei, and their numbers were far too great to ignore.

Was security in Sichuan Province really that terrible? No, even so, wouldn't the Beggars' Sect and the Lower District Sect have noticed them?

I walked on with that question in mind until the passage—wide enough for ten grown men to walk abreast—finally ended and opened into a vast chamber.

[1823] In Korean, *Salseong* ("Slaughter Saint") and *Ssalseong* ("Rice Saint") differ by one consonant. The altered title also continues the wet-dream joke.

The words slipped out before I knew it.

"…Huh. Would you look at that."

The chamber could have easily held over a thousand people. Dozens of night-shining pearls embedded in the ceiling cast a soft glow, while jars filled with dry rations and fasting pills stood in one corner alongside piles of weapons.

But none of that was what surprised me most.

What is that?

Strange patterns covered the entire cavern floor.

Carved in regular arrangements like intricate gears, they looked like the ruins of an ancient kingdom forgotten long ago.

"Is that perhaps the thing you mentioned earlier…?"

At my question, Cheongpung the Ancient Sword, Sect Leader of the Qingcheng Sect, nodded gravely.

"That is correct. That is the strange formation I spoke of."

I had wondered if it could really be a formation, but apparently it was.

I had encountered all kinds of mechanisms and formations at the Star-Array Grand Banquet, but I had never seen one this large or this bizarre.

This goes beyond strange. It's downright grotesque.

Maybe it was the patterns. There was something both mysterious and dangerous about them.

Jeok Cheongang seemed to share my thoughts.

"But what in the world are those bizarre patterns?"

"We have yet to determine that ourselves."

Extinction Divine Nun added to Cheongpung the Ancient Sword's answer.

"We cannot jump to conclusions. We copied part of the formation and showed it to several renowned scholars and distinguished figures, but none recognized it. We cannot entirely rule out the possibility that it is some unknown script from the Western Regions."[1824]

Before I knew it, a remark slipped from my lips.

"Uh, that isn't writing."

"…"

"…"

"…"

Every eye turned toward me. The Slaughter Saint, who had remained silent ever since we entered the cavern, abruptly spoke.

"Your basis?"

"My… basis?"

[1824] The Western Regions is a historical Chinese term for lands to the west of China, particularly Central Asia.

“If you make such a claim, you must have sound grounds for it. Stop asking questions and answer.”

Of course I had grounds. Conclusive grounds that neither a renowned scholar who had devoured tens of thousands of books nor an eminent martial artist who had spent a lifetime roaming the Murim could refute.

The Integrated Language Pack.

The *Integrated Language Pack* automatically translated every language through the power of the System.

It didn’t just let me communicate. I could read and write any language as well.

It was thanks to the *Integrated Language Pack* that I had been able to speak with the Skeleton Warlord in the modern world.

Yet despite the interpretation function being constantly active like a passive Skill, the patterns that made up the formation remained unchanged.

That was definitive proof they weren’t writing.

The problem was…

How am I supposed to explain that?

I shouldn’t have said anything. I should have kept my mouth shut.

But it was already too late. As the Slaughter Saint’s gaze grew more intense, I stammered,

“Bo… bo.”

“Boobs?”

The Rice Saint’s eyebrow twitched.

It was the first emotion he had shown. He had clearly remembered the wet-dream incident.

“Ah, no, not boobs.”

“Breasts, then?”

“…”

Please. Don’t say things like that with a face completely devoid of emotion.

“No, that’s not what I meant.”

As I frantically waved my hands, Jeok Cheongang suddenly cut in.

“Are you threatening my Disciple? How dare you threaten the Fire King’s heir and the Young Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan?”

“Threaten him? There is no need, but neither is it beyond me.”

“I intended to let this pass since I happened to owe you my life, but if this is how you mean to act, Mun, then this old man cannot stand idle.”

The atmosphere grew increasingly hostile. I squeezed my eyes shut and shouted,

“I-I took a guess!”

“…”

"…"

"…"

"I thought I might have seen something like it in a book before… and it just didn't feel like writing, so I guessed."

A heavy silence descended.

The Slaughter Saint let out a nearly inaudible sigh, then asked Jeok Cheongang,

"So that fellow is the heir of the Fire King and the Young Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan?"

Jeok Cheongang fell silent for a moment before answering.

"Now that I think about it, he never underwent the formal initiation ceremony."

"…"

"So strictly speaking, he isn't yet an official Disciple of our sect. Which means he should still be considered a member of the Jin Family of Taiyuan…"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes met mine. He quietly looked away.

"I shall say no more."

"…"

What did he mean, *no more*? He had already said everything there was to say.

Having witnessed the complete collapse of trust between Master and Disciple, Extinction Divine Nun and Cheongpung the Ancient Sword awkwardly changed the subject.

"Ahem. In any case, it seems we must continue investigating this strange formation."

"F-Fellow Daoist Jin and Senior Jeok's insights have been most helpful."

Heaven knew they hadn't helped at all. Earth knew it. Everyone here knew it.

Even a stray dog in an alley wouldn't believe that nonsense.

Having brought the situation to a close with such an obvious lie, Cheongpung the Ancient Sword turned to Extinction Divine Nun with a troubled expression.

"Still, it is truly difficult to believe. To bring so many people here with nothing more than a formation…"

"Indeed. If such a thing is possible, does that not mean they could appear anywhere under heaven?"

Wait. What did they just say?

I had been staring at the ground, frustrated by my inability to explain myself and still suffering from the aftermath of the boob incident. I abruptly raised my head.

"What is it, Benefactor Jin?"

"No, it's just… I think this is the first I've heard either of you mention that part about the formation."

"Hmm? You mean the Moving Formation?"

"…The Moving Formation?"

"That is correct. According to the Third Fiend, that strange formation is called a Moving Formation. We cannot know how much of his absurd story to believe, but he said Dark Heaven used it to travel hundreds of li."[1825]

A Moving Formation. They said it was a Moving Formation.

Even if a critic in angular horn-rimmed glasses had suddenly walked out and declared, "I give this formation four and a half stars," I couldn't have been more bewildered.

This sounds familiar.

A formation capable of transporting hundreds of people across hundreds of li.

The more I thought about it, the harder my heart pounded and the drier my lips became.

What if this so-called Moving Formation was *that thing* I was thinking of?

No. That can't be.

But despite my desperate denial, my Adam's apple bobbed heavily.

"Is this formation still operational?"

I had directed the question at the two Sect Leaders, but the Slaughter Saint answered.

"The Third Fiend. I caught him here myself."

"…He tried to escape through the Moving Formation."

"Yes. But that was only his intention."

"You mean…"

"As he later confessed, he tried to activate the formation. Nothing happened."

"Oh."

"One thing is certain. There is no flow of qi whatsoever within that formation. It has completely lost its power. Nothing remains but an empty shell."

After finishing his explanation in a flat voice, the Slaughter Saint added,

"Judging from the circumstances that have come to light, Dark Heaven is without a doubt the successor to the Demonic Cult. The Demonic Cult possesses countless monstrous martial arts and supreme techniques, so it would not be strange if they had any number of bizarre arts."

I had heard what kind of place the Demonic Cult was so many times that it had been drilled into my head.

A powerful religious organization that was the very embodiment of demonic, heterodox arts.

Although it had ultimately been defeated in the Great Faction War, it had managed to overwhelm the entire Murim for so long because of the countless monstrous martial arts and supreme techniques it possessed.

[1825] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi). Hundreds of li would be roughly 100–500 km (62–311 mi).

So this formation is one of the many bizarre arts passed down from the Demonic Cult?

No matter how much I thought about it, I couldn't figure it out. Maybe all the fusion-fantasy novels I had read were getting in the way. This sort of thing showed up in them all the time, which somehow only made it more confusing.

They got away with it just fine in Mukhyung. *Ugh. I shouldn't have read a novel that never even got an ending.*

Still, just in case, I decided to memorize the formation's arrangement and patterns.

I was staring intently at the Moving Formation, engraving every detail into my mind, when the Slaughter Saint suddenly spoke.

"Judging by your behavior, you seem to know something. Does anything come to mind?"

"…"

What excuse was I supposed to make now?

Chapter 373

The trip back was short.

On the way there, we had at least slowed down to exchange information. But in game terms, this was a deluxe party with no fewer than five Supreme Peak masters traveling together.

The distance that would have taken an ordinary person half a day to cover had shrunk to almost nothing.

“You’ve worked hard, Benefactor Jin.”

“And you must still be tired. Thank you for coming with us.”

As we neared the Sichuan Tang Clan, the two Sect Leaders turned to address me. I shrugged.

“It’s nothing. I didn’t really help much, anyway.”

“True.”

“He certainly didn’t.”

“…”

It was true that I hadn’t been much help, but wasn’t that a little harsh?

Cheongpung the Ancient Sword gave me a faint smile, then clasped his hands toward the Slaughter Saint and Jeok Cheongang.

“I’m grateful to both of you Seniors as well. I apologize for making you come all this way for nothing.”

The Slaughter Saint and Jeok Cheongang answered at the same time.

“It was indeed a pointless trip.”

“Next time, don’t do anything you’ll need to apologize for. Understood?”

“…Ah. Yes.”

That was exactly how I felt.

The Slaughter Saint continued, addressing the visibly uncomfortable Cheongpung the Ancient Sword.

“And… I hope you won’t come looking for me again.”

He wasn’t telling them to call on him less often because it was a bother. After briefly returning as the Slaughter Saint, he intended to go back to being Mungyeong, the young medical apprentice.

Everyone present understood what he meant.

The two Sect Leaders were the most flustered of all.

“S-Senior, that…”

“Benefactor, might you reconsider?”

Instead of answering, the Slaughter Saint gave them a dry look.

After a moment of silence, Cheongpung the Ancient Sword and Extinction Divine Nun sighed softly and nodded.

"…We will do so."

"I shall respect your wishes. For now."

For now.

The last two words were heavily emphasized. The Slaughter Saint's quiet voice slipped between his lips.

"My decision has not changed. Coming this time was nothing more than a passing whim."

It was a firm answer that left not even the slightest room for argument. The Slaughter Saint's gaze shifted toward Jeok Cheongang and me.

"I trust you two understand that as well."

Jeok Cheongang suddenly spoke.

"Are you going to pretend to be a medical apprentice again? It doesn't suit you."

"It isn't an act. The Slaughter Saint no longer exists. Only a medical apprentice remains."

"If a tiger drapes itself in goatskin, does that make it a goat?"

"If it hides its teeth and claws, even a tiger can become a goat."

"But you revealed your claws in the end. Didn't you?"

A shallow crease formed between the Slaughter Saint's brows.

"You've grown more talkative with age. You owe me a debt, after all."

"…Damn. I can't argue when you're not wrong."

"I'll take that as an answer."

Having dismissed Jeok Cheongang, the Slaughter Saint glanced at me.

"And you?"

"Me?"

"Who else is left?"

"No, that's not what I meant. Do I get a choice?"

"Of course. You have two."

The Slaughter Saint spoke with an impassive expression.

"First, you can loudly announce that the young medical apprentice named Mungyeong is actually the Slaughter Saint, then be found dead without a soul knowing how. Second, you can keep your mouth shut so no one notices, treat me as you did before, and leave quietly."

"…"

"Which will you choose?"

Wow. The choices were so difficult that I was speechless for a moment.

After swallowing hard, I opened my mouth.

"The second one."

"A wise choice."

"Yeah."[1826]

The Slaughter Saint had been about to nod at my prompt answer when he suddenly stopped.

"What did you just say?"

"Why?"

"What?"

"No, I mean, why are you acting like that? You told me to treat you as I did before."

"…!"

"…!"

The two Sect Leaders stood there with their mouths hanging open. The Slaughter Saint was silent for a moment before asking Jeok Cheongang, who had begun chuckling.

"Is this fellow insane?"

"He's always been like that. Gives you a headache, doesn't he?"

"I want to smash his skull in."

I bowed deeply before he could make good on that threat.

"Ah, I got confused for a moment. My apologies."

"Not even a dog would believe that, but I'll let it slide this once."

Had it been too obvious that I was trying to mess with him while pretending it was a mistake? The Slaughter Saint glared at me with narrowed eyes before speaking.

"In any case, watch yourself from now on. Aside from those present, no one knows the truth about me. Ah, that boy Cheongpung is an exception. As is my Disciple, of course."

"Cheongpung knew too?"

"Yes. Aside from him, everyone who saw me that day is dead."

Now *that* was a thorough cleanup.

I finally understood why there hadn't been a single prisoner at the Sichuan Tang Clan.

The Masked Slaughter Saint.[1827] Once the mask came off, panelists and audience members alike dropped dead.

The more I think about it, the stranger this feels. Mungyeong was the Slaughter Saint all along.

[1826] The Korean reply *eung* is an informal "yes"; Jin deliberately uses a level of address too casual for the Slaughter Saint.

[1827] This refers to *King of Mask Singer*, a Korean television competition in which masked performers reveal their identities before panelists and an audience.

Memories flashed through my mind, from our first meeting on the Yangtze to the present.

Which of the sides he had shown me was real, and which was a lie?

The innocent young medical apprentice I had known no longer existed. All that remained was the greatest assassin under heaven, his eyes dry and emotionless.

Before I knew it, a question slipped out.

“Why are you so determined to hide who you are?”

The Slaughter Saint, moving toward the Sichuan Tang Clan now visible in the distance, stopped dead.

After a brief silence, he answered with unexpected calm.

“Because I’m sick to death of the Murim.”

“Is that why you left?”

“Yes. I swore to the heavens that I would never take another life.”

In this place—the Murim—assassins were despised.

Neither the orthodox factions nor practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts welcomed them.

They were seen not as martial artists pursuing higher realms of martial arts, but as people born solely to kill.

How much blood had one assassin spilled—and how deeply had he been stained by it—before earning the sobriquet Slaughter Saint?

I thought I understood how he felt, at least to some extent.

But…

“On the other hand, I’m a little curious.”

“What?”

“Why you came back to the Murim you hate so much.”

“…What nonsense are you talking about, saying I returned?”

The Slaughter Saint’s eyes sank deeper.

“I had no choice. It was unavoidable.”

“I don’t know. If that’s how you put it, I have nothing to say. But it seems like you made at least a few choices yourself. For example…”

I scratched the back of my head and continued.

“You asked to travel with some martial artists you met on the Yangtze because you were headed in the same direction. A few days later, you happened to run into them again and casually revealed your identity. Or you borrowed my name to order the Successor Beggar of the Beggars’ Sect to rescue Emei Sect, while you went to Qingcheng…”

“Enough.”

“Yes. I was about to stop anyway. Now that I’ve listed them one by one, there are quite a few.”

“What is it you want to hear? That I should have stood by and watched countless people—including you and your Master—die?”

“Of course not. I’m truly grateful, Great Hero.”

There was no sarcasm in my voice. I meant it with one hundred percent sincerity.

If he hadn’t stepped in at the right moment, countless people would have died or been injured.

Jeok Cheongang and I would certainly have been among them.

But the Slaughter Saint’s response to my words was as dry as desert sand.

“Don’t call me Great Hero.”

“Then what should I call you?”

The Slaughter Saint stared at me without speaking, then turned away.

He took a step toward the Sichuan Tang Clan, now no more than a large speck in the distance, and glided forward like a ghost.

The boy’s voice scattered on the wind.

“Mungyeong. That is enough.”

Was it really enough?

Only he knew the answer.

I shrugged and replied,

“Yeah, got it, Mungyeong.”

“…!”

At that moment, the figure walking ahead of us stumbled.

When I returned to the pavilion, two leeches latched onto me.

One was Hyuk Mujin, whom I could never decide was my right arm or my pinky. The other was a beggar whose skin had gotten a little whiter, as if he had started scrubbing off some dirt lately.

“Why is Mungyeong like that? He somehow seems a little gloomier.”

“That’s understandable. His Master, the Divine Physician, was injured, and there are so many patients waiting for treatment.”

“Oh, I see. But Captain, where did you go with Mungyeong?”

“Isn’t it obvious? He looked down, so the Captain took him out for some fresh air. Why are you so stupid?”

“Huh. In all my life, I never thought I’d hear that from a beggar. I may look like this, but I’ve read several hundred books. I’ve never been called stupid before.”

As far as I could tell, both of them were just stupid.

I swallowed the words *Slaughter Saint* hovering on the tip of my tongue. Those two would never discover Mungyeong's true identity, even if they died and came back to life.

Then again, with acting skills like that, anyone would be fooled.

The instant people's attention turned toward him, the Slaughter Saint returned to being Mungyeong.

No one suspected his identity just because the cheerful young medical apprentice seemed a little gloomier than usual.

No one could even have guessed.

"I'd give you credit if you'd read the Four Books and Three Classics,[1828] but all you've done is read martial arts novels nonstop. What books are you talking about?"

"I read romance novels too. Haven't you heard of Gwiyeommi?"[1829]

"Wait. Gwiyeommi? You mean the scholar who wrote *The Temptation of a Young Prodigy*, *That Bastard Was Strong*, and all those others?"

"Oh, you know him."

"Of course I do. When I was a one-knot Disciple,[1830] I used the money I'd begged for to rent one of his books, and the beggar chief beat me black and blue. Damn, if I ran into that bastard now, I'd lay into him with the Dog-Beating Staff Technique. I'd—"

Whack!

"Gah!"

"Aagh!"

I kicked both idiots in the ass as they happily reminisced, drove them out, and slammed the door shut.

I already had more than enough to think about. Why had those bastards come here just to make a racket?

Finally, some peace and quiet.

Cheongpung was probably running all over the place by now, and I'd told Jeok Cheongang to rest for the entire day. No one would come looking for me for a while.

I lay down on the soft bed and decided to take care of something I'd been putting off.

Check unread messages.

Ding. Ding. Ding-ding!

System windows filled the air as an endless stream of chimes rang out.

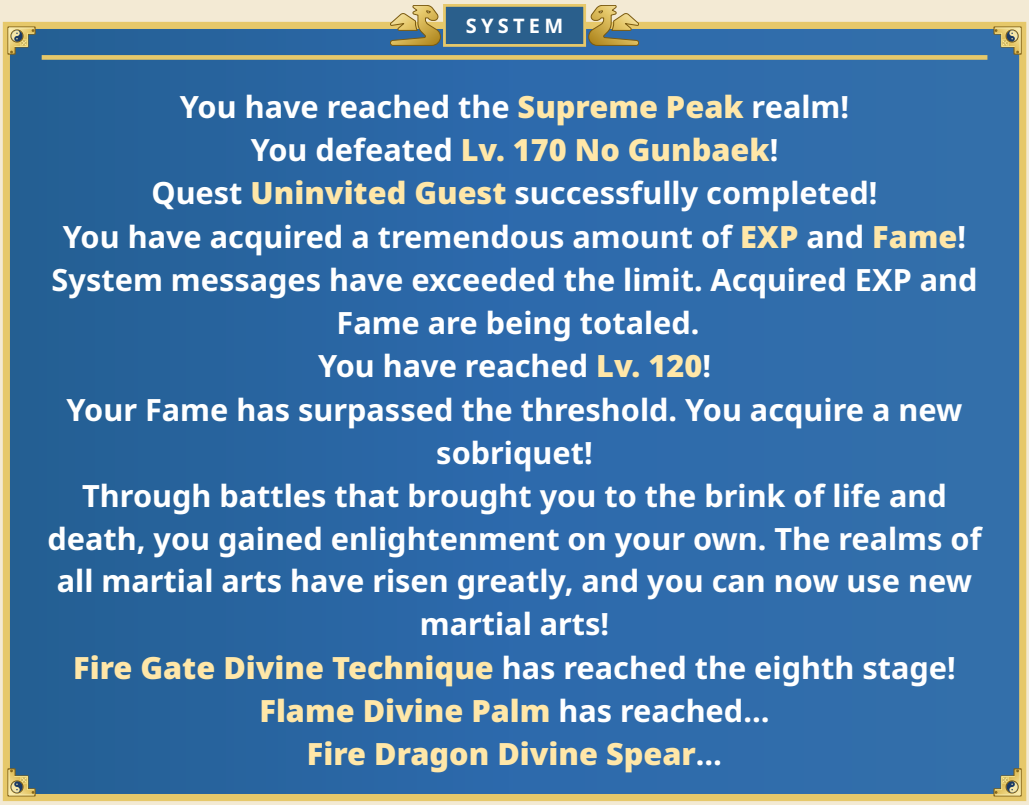
[1828] The Four Books and Three Classics are foundational texts of Confucian learning.

[1829] *Gwiyeommi* (□□□) is a literary pen name meaning "precious, bewitching beauty."

[1830] The Beggars' Sect marks disciples' ranks with knots; one knot denotes a low rank.

This had happened a few times before, but this had to be a new record.

Momentarily speechless, I began checking the important messages one by one.



Countless requests for handshakes—no, a veritable feast of messages.

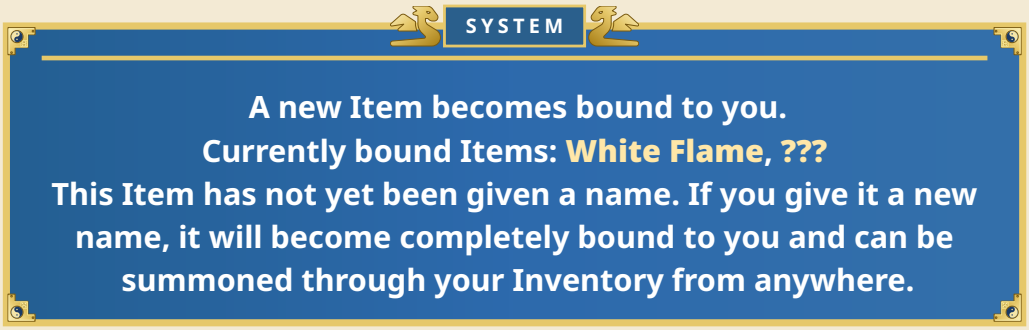
My eyes started spinning just from skimming them.

“...Holy shit.”

What was all this?

I was almost stunned to discover that half the unread messages still remained.

Just as I scrolled down to see how many were left, something unusual caught my eye.



“This pops up here...”

The Modern World and Murim inventories were separate. However, bound Items like White Flame weren’t restricted by space and could be pulled out and used anywhere.

I'd already felt that White Flame alone wasn't enough, so this was quite a stroke of luck.

If they're giving it to me, I'll gladly take it.

I was just about to check my Inventory, brimming with anticipation, when—

Knock, knock, knock.

A knock sounded on the door, and someone poked their head inside.

"Captain. It's me, Mujin…"

"Get lost."

"No, that's not what I meant."

"Hyung's[1831] busy. Go read some Gwiyeommi novels."[1832]

"Oh, Captain, you've read them too?"

"…You little bastard, seriously."

This wouldn't do.

Before cracking open the Item, I'd have to crack that bastard open first.

I shot up from the bed, and Hyuk Mujin hurriedly shouted,

"Henan! It's Henan!"

"What?"

"An investigation team has arrived from Henan! They're looking for you, Captain."

"…An investigation team?"

I frowned at Hyuk Mujin's completely contextless explanation.

Ding.

A familiar alert reached my ears.

[1831] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean term used by a man for an older brother or older male acquaintance. Here Jin uses it to refer to himself when speaking to Mujin.

[1832] *Gwiyeommi* (□□□) is a literary pen name meaning "precious, bewitching beauty."

Chapter 374

Tang Horyong, the Master of Poison Dragon Pavilion, rose from his seat to greet his guest.

An imposing man had just opened the door and entered, and an indescribable pressure radiated from him.

“You’ve had a long journey.”

“Compared to what the Sichuan Tang Clan has endured, it was nothing. Allow me to offer my deepest condolences once again.”

Despite his rough features, the man’s voice was low and gentle, yet possessed a force that compelled others to listen.

It was the sort of presence only a leader of men possessed. The man’s gaze was mild yet unfathomably deep, and it suddenly reminded Tang Horyong of someone.

It feels as though I’m facing another older cousin…

That realization left Tang Horyong more than a little unsettled.

He had heard that the man before him was still young—not yet forty.

His older cousin, on the other hand, was an extraordinary figure not only in age but also in his standing within the Murim.

He was an iron-willed Family Head who had accomplished countless military feats during the Great Faction War and rebuilt his fallen family stronger than ever.

Tang Sadok, the Myriad-Poison Asura.

Tang Horyong, the Acting Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, sighed inwardly as he thought of his older cousin, who had yet to regain consciousness.

Please wake soon and lead us, Family Head.

Tang Horyong had been born a martial artist.

He prided himself on having mastered poison and hidden weapons, but leading a family was an entirely different matter.

Especially lately, countless problems had been pouring in from every direction, leaving him no time even to think about the grief and anger caused by the loss of his blood relatives.

If only someone like this were standing in my place.

In that sense, Tang Horyong couldn’t help envying the man before him.

Nor was he judging him solely by his first impression. He had already heard plenty of rumors about the man.

Even if only a quarter of them were true, the man was more than capable of leading a family.

“Sir Tang, is there something on my face?”

“Ah, no. I’ve been so distracted that I forgot my manners. My apologies.”

At Tang Horyong’s hurried apology, the man nodded gravely.

"Not at all. It's understandable after everything you've suffered."

In truth, even the word *devastating* fell short of describing the damage the Sichuan Tang Clan had suffered.

Nearly ninety percent of the clan's people had died, and most of the Tang Clan's grounds had been destroyed.

Their only consolation was that the family line had survived, but restoring the clan to its former glory would take many years.

"Our fellow martial artists throughout Sichuan have gone out of their way to help us, but… I fear what lies ahead."

If Tang Sadok, the Family Head, had been in his position, he would never have shown weakness under any circumstances.

Tang Horyong was different.

At his honest words, the man gently ran his long fingers over his teacup.

"I believe you know why I came here, Sir Tang."

"I understand that you came to investigate the Three-Gate Bloodbath."

"To be precise, when I first left Henan, my purpose was to find the culprit who murdered the late Poison King Tang Sadok and the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun. However, the situation changed drastically on the way here."

"That's right. Dark Heaven, those bastards beyond the pale, finally revealed their fangs."

"Although we already had the incident in Henan as precedent, the fact that they dared to attack three renowned clans and sects across the land at once proves that war is already upon us."

Small disturbances breed greater chaos.

But Dark Heaven's existence could no longer be concealed, nor was there any reason to hide it.

Seven days and nights had passed since the horrific Three-Gate Bloodbath.

By now, word without feet would have traveled a thousand li,[1833] and countless messenger pigeons would be flying to every corner of the realm.

And war—not mere chaos—had brought people together.

"I heard the orthodox Murim has been rallying in Henan since the Shaolin Bloodshed. Then, perhaps…"

"For now, they are still making preparations. But it is already a foregone conclusion."

The man continued in a weighty voice.

"That brings me to my proposal. Would you consider going to Henan?"

"Henan."

"Yes. What you're thinking of will happen soon."

[1833] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (310 mi).

After a brief silence, Tang Horyong spoke.

“I’m grateful to be invited to such an honorable occasion, but I cannot leave now. As you know, as Acting Family Head, I must remain with the members of our family…”

“Sir Tang.”

“Go on.”

“As you just said, you are the Acting Family Head. Naturally, you cannot leave the members of the Tang Clan behind.”

“…!”

Only then did Tang Horyong understand what the man was proposing. His mouth fell open.

It was something he had never dared even consider.

“So you’re saying that we should move our family headquarters?”

“Well…”

The man’s clear gaze, as though it could see straight through him, settled on Tang Horyong.

“Great Hero Mae Jonghak told me that a war even greater than the Great Faction War would soon break out.”

“The Sword Saint…”

Tang Horyong swallowed a groan.

That could not be the Sword Saint’s opinion alone.

The Shaolin Bloodshed had awakened the anger and vigilance of countless orthodox martial artists, and the new Murim Alliance was already poised to take shape.

The entire orthodox Murim was preparing for the coming war.

Can our family survive in a situation like this?

The question flashed through his mind, and his heart sank.

The Sichuan Tang Clan had already suffered a blow unprecedented in its history.

Moreover, the Qingcheng Sect and Emei Sect had also lost a considerable portion of their forces.

If the enemy attacked again, there was little hope of stopping them.

“Haa…”

As Tang Horyong sighed with a dazed expression, a quiet voice reached his ears.

“Sir Tang, why do you think the Sichuan Tang Clan has endured for the past several hundred years?”

“That is…”

“Because it was the Tang Clan. Even if you remove the first two characters—Sichuan—that fact does not change.”

“…!”

"If you make the decision, the orthodox Murim will help the Tang Clan."

Tang Horyong trembled before finally managing to speak.

"We have made countless enemies over the years. Even among the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, there are those who regard our family with hostility. Will that truly cause no problems?"

"Everything will be handled fairly and openly. Put your mind at ease and establish a new home. Henan, Shaanxi, or…"

A gentle smile touched the man's lips.

"Shanxi would be a fine choice as well."

"Shanxi?"

"Just say the word. I have plenty of land to spare."

Tang Horyong suddenly remembered one fact he had overlooked.

The man before him was the Alliance Leader who had unified the Shanxi Murim, as well as the greatest landowner and wealthiest man in Shanxi Province.

"Thank you. Truly, thank you, Great Hero Jin!"

"Think nothing of it."

At that moment, Jin Wikyung, the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, returned the Acting Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan's clasped-fist salute with courtesy and dignity.

Clunk.

"Um, I heard you called for me."

Jin Wikyung spotted a young man poking his head through the gap in the pavilion door and unleashed a lion's roar.

"My youngest!"

Thud-thud-thud-thud—crash!

He charged like an enraged bull.

As Tang Horyong watched the two brothers reunite in something that fell somewhere between an embrace and a collision, he recalled one of the rumors he had heard about Jin Wikyung.

They say he's completely helpless when it comes to his younger brothers.

The Alliance Leader who had unified Shanxi Murim and the greatest landowner in Shanxi Province was nowhere to be seen.

In his place stood a hopelessly doting fool.

He's still young, so he lacks experience. He can't compare to my older cousin, who remains perfectly levelheaded at all times. Yes, of course.

Tang Horyong had no way of knowing about Mimi-chan.[1834]

[1834] The Japanese suffix *-chan* is an affectionate form of address.

“My youngest!”

Jin Wikyung charged at me with tears flying from his eyes and swept me into a fierce embrace.

I’d been in the Murim for two years now. I’d endured this kind of thing more times than I cared to remember, so I’d expected a reaction like this.

Crack!

…But I hadn’t expected that.

Seriously, why did I hear my bones shifting?

I sighed as he squeezed my entire body like an anaconda in the Amazon jungle.

Still, since he was happy to see me, I let him hug me without resisting. His reaction had never been this intense before, though.

“Wait, Hyung-nim.[1835] Let go and then we can talk. Let go.”

“Hyung-nim?[1836] Why are you using such a stiff form of address? Haven’t I told you to just call me hyung?[1837] You’ve changed. You’ve really changed!”

“Okay, I get it, so let me go now.”

“You used to speak informally when you were little! Why are you being so polite now? You’ve changed. You’ve really changed!”

“Let go, goddammit.”

“Gasp! You never swore, even at the height of your rebellious phase! You’ve changed—”

“Wow, that refrain is driving me insane.”

Was being a martial artist his main job and being a Dementor his side gig?

Shuddering at the feeling of my soul being sucked out, I reached out.

Whoosh—crash!

Jin Wikyung’s huge body slammed headfirst into the ground with a heavy thud.

A middle-aged man from the Sichuan Tang Clan, who had been watching us, let out a startled groan.

“It’s all right. Really. We’re just playing around.”

“N-No, but…”

“Look. He’s getting right back up.”

Just as I’d said, Jin Wikyung sprang to his feet as if nothing had happened, tears of emotion welling in his eyes.

[1835] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

[1836] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

[1837] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man. *Hyung-nim* is a more respectful form.

"You've grown even stronger. That's my youngest."

His utter lack of change made me snort with laughter.

"You really haven't changed."

"Haven't changed? Do you know how worried I've been these past two months? I couldn't sleep at night, and I lost my appetite until I was nothing but skin and bones."

I looked over his enormous, muscular frame and muttered, "You seem to have plenty of skin and bones."

Come to think of it, two months.

That much time had already passed.

It struck me anew that the time for me to return was drawing near.

If spending ten days in one world meant that only an hour or so passed in the other…

About six hours must have passed. The plane might be landing soon.

The timing couldn't have been better. I'd built up quite a bit of fatigue while overcoming the massive hurdle that was the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Without wasting any more words, I got straight to the point.

"When are we leaving?"

"My youngest, you must have suffered so much… Hm?"

Jin Wikyung, who had been anxiously looking me over, froze.

"What did you just say?"

"You came to take me with you, didn't you? Oh, and the Third Fiend too."

Jin Wikyung's eyes widened.

"How did you know?"

The middle-aged man, who seemed to hold an important position in the Sichuan Tang Clan, also spoke in surprise.

"Great Hero Jin, did you not come to investigate the full circumstances of the incident?"

"I did, but several members of the investigation team, including myself, will be returning to Henan. Just before we reached Sichuan, we received orders to escort the Third Fiend, one of the chief culprits behind the Three-Gate Bloodbath."

"Then what about your proposal concerning our family?"

"That offer remains valid, of course. But relocating right away would be difficult for the Tang Clan."

"That is true. The Family Head is still in no condition to travel such a great distance, and we must obtain the consent of the other clan members."

"Yes. And…"

After speaking quietly with the middle-aged man for a moment, Jin Wikyung sent me a covert Sound Transmission.

But how did you know?

I can put two and two together. It seemed obvious from the circumstances.

Ah, my youngest. What terrible ordeal did you endure to become smarter as well?

…

That rubbed me the wrong way.

I hadn’t actually figured it out from the circumstances. I knew because a Quest to escort the Third Fiend had appeared.

“So when are we leaving?”

Having just finished his conversation, Jin Wikyung answered my question.

“If you already knew, that makes this easier. The sooner, the better. Are you ready?”

“I didn’t bring anything but the two balls between my legs. All I have to do is go.”

Plus two bundles wrapped tightly in bandages.

Jin Wikyung nodded and turned to the middle-aged man.

“Sir Tang, where is the Third Fiend?”

The man he had addressed as Sir Tang replied, “We bound their limbs and confined them under close watch. Ever since their testicles were crushed, they’ve tried to kill themselves at every opportunity, so you’ll need to be careful.”

“…Good grief.”

I’d want to die too if that happened to me.

In any case, everything was in place for us to move quickly.

Jin Wikyung considered it for a moment, then answered decisively.

“Then half a shichen.[1838] We’ll leave within half a shichen.[1839] Is that acceptable?”

“No problem.”

The instant I answered without hesitation, a frantic commotion arose outside the pavilion, followed by someone shouting.

“The Family Head! The Family Head has awakened!”

Jin Wikyung amended his words in a lukewarm voice.

“One shichen.[1840] Let’s make it one shichen.[1841]”

“…Yes. That sounds better.”

What a shame. I could’ve taken the Myriad-Poison Ring and run.

[1838] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[1839] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[1840] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[1841] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Chapter 375

There was an order to visiting the sick.

When word spread that Tang Sadok—the Family Head and an elder of the clan—had awakened, the members of the Tang Clan dropped everything and came running.

But not all hundred-plus of them could see him.

“Benefactor, when can we go see Grandpa Tang?”

“Hard to say. The people ahead of us have been in there for a while, so they should be coming out soon.”

“Oh, I see.”

Cheongpung nodded at my answer.

Wait. Cheongpung?

“What are you doing here? When did you get here?”

“Just now.”

He had joined the conversation so naturally that I hadn’t even noticed him. But why had he come here?

As if he had read my mind, Cheongpung pointed at his chest.

“Mimi said she wanted to see him.”

“…?”

What the hell had I just heard?

Now he could even communicate with a snake. Was this guy from Slytherin instead of Huashan?

Cheongpung tilted his head at my suspicious stare.

“Why are you looking at my forehead all of a sudden? Is there something on it?”

“I was just checking whether you had a lightning-shaped scar on your forehead.”

“What?”

“There is such a thing.”

The instant I finished speaking—

Clunk.

The tightly shut door of the infirmary opened, and about a dozen people emerged.

They were among the few surviving direct descendants of the Sichuan Tang Clan. Tang Horyong, whom I had met before, was among them.

“Whew…”

His eyes bloodshot, he looked up at the sky before walking toward us.

“The Family Head wishes to see you.”

“We’ve been waiting.”

Jin Wikyung nodded and led the way. Cheongpung and I followed him into the infirmary.

We walked through the heavy smell of medicinal decoctions until a physician with a white cloth covering his nose and mouth led us into a treatment room.

At last, we came face-to-face with several familiar people.

“Cough… You came.”

Tang Sadok’s condition was serious at a glance. His limbs were broken, and the qi within him was unstable from his internal injuries.

The Divine Physician, who exchanged a brief glance with us, stopped Tang Sadok as he tried to sit up.

“Family Head, did I not tell you not to move?”

“This old man is a sinner. I committed a crime deserving of death, so it is only right that I ask for punishment.”

Tang Sadok shook his pale head, stared directly at me, and continued.

“I will make no pathetic excuses. The Western Heaven Demon Lord went to the underground prison because I told him about it.”

I folded my arms at an angle.

“Ah. No wonder.”

“…?”

“Why?”

Tang Sadok asked with a flustered expression.

“Ah, you knew?”

“Of course I didn’t know at first. Things were too hectic back then. But when I thought about it later, I started wondering how the hell that bastard knew where the Myriad-Poison Ring was.”

Only a tiny number of people knew its location.

Cheongpung might have looked as light as a flower petal, but he was as steadfast as the roots of a tree. That left Tang Sadok as the only person who could have revealed it.

“Why did you do it?”

“He said that if I told him where the Myriad-Poison Ring was, he would preserve our family’s bloodline.”

“And you believed him?”

“This old man was foolish. My judgment was clouded for a moment, and I did something I never should have done.”

“At least you realize that much.”

Tang Sadok’s eyes trembled as he looked at me.

“The reason this old man survived must have been Heaven’s will. I was spared so that I might apologize to you and receive my punishment.”

"Then what punishment do you seek, Family Head?"

The cold voice belonged to Jin Wikyung, who had been silently listening to our conversation.

"Are you the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"Yes. I am also the elder brother who raised my two younger brothers as if they were my own sons."

Unmistakable anger smoldered in Jin Wikyung's dark eyes.

"It was something no one who walks the righteous path should have done."

"I know. No… I am well aware. That is why I ask to be punished."

"What if I order you to take your own life?"

"…!"

Everyone, myself included, stared at Jin Wikyung in shock.

Everyone except Tang Sadok.

His expression perfectly calm, he answered.

"I betrayed the principles of the Way, yet because all of you risked your lives to fight for us, our family's bloodline will endure. If this worthless old man's life can serve as atonement, I will gladly offer it."

A brief silence followed. Then Jin Wikyung sighed.

"Whew…"

He regarded Tang Sadok with a complicated look before turning to me.

"What will you do?"

"…What? Have him take his own life?"

"Anything."

Having the hilt of a sword suddenly placed in my hand made my heart clench.

Especially when the life hanging from the other end belonged to the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

Look how icy the mood suddenly got.

Of course, this wasn't something I could just laugh off. I wasn't some perfectly impartial, broad-minded Great Hero of Benevolence and Righteousness. When I figured out the whole story, anger had quietly begun simmering inside me.

Everyone's lives had been on the line back then, not just mine.

But…

"Forget it. I don't want to take it that far."

The truth was, part of me understood Tang Sadok's position.

If I had to weigh an outsider I had met only a few times against my own blood—people I was duty-bound to protect as the head of my family—I might have made the same choice.

Besides, I owed him.

Tang Sadok's help had played a major part in Jeok Cheongang's awakening.

Even if there had been a certain deal involved, Tang Sadok had still been the one who lent us a divine artifact without telling even his own blood relatives.

"So let's call it even. No, that's going too far. Let's just say the Sichuan Tang Clan owes us a huge debt for what happened."

When I finished, Cheongpung and the Divine Physician spoke up.

"It was definitely Grandpa Tang's fault that Benefactor was put in danger... but I'll follow Benefactor's wishes, too."

"I have already forgotten about it. If I have one wish as a physician, it is for the Family Head to recover as soon as possible. There are still clan members who survived, aren't there?"

Jin Wikyung spoke last. Unlike before, there was no longer any anger in his voice.

No—perhaps he had known what my answer would be from the start.

"So that is what they say. What do you think, Family Head?"

"...!"

Tang Sadok's eyes shook with emotion as he looked at us.

After a brief silence, a hoarse voice escaped his lips.

"This old man... The Sichuan Tang Clan owes all of you a tremendous debt of gratitude."

The instant Tang Sadok bowed his head in heartfelt thanks—

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

Confessing one's sins is difficult, but something else requires even greater courage:
Forgiveness.
Hidden Quest Atonement and Forgiveness successfully completed!
Lv. 115 Tang Sadok expresses his profound gratitude for your goodwill. He and the Sichuan Tang Clan will never forget the kindness and aid you showed them today. The people of the Sichuan Tang Clan will remember you as their Benefactor!
You have acquired the Title: Tang Clan's Benefactor!
You have received a tremendous amount of EXP and Fame as a reward for completing the Hidden Quest!
Level Up!

What the hell? A Hidden Quest out of nowhere?

While I stood dazed by the unexpected System notifications, something cold brushed between my legs and slipped past.

Sssrikk, sssriririk.

“Mimi, you little rascal.”

Seeing Mimi and Tang Sadok reunited after so long reminded me of something I had momentarily forgotten.

“Oh, right. About the Myriad-Poison Ring… Luckily, I’ve kept it safe all this time—”

“Is that so?”

Tang Sadok cut in before I could finish.

“Then continue keeping it.”

“Yes, then I’ll keep it… Wait, what?”

“I entrust our family’s divine artifact to you. Consider it a token of our gratitude to our Benefactor, and please do not refuse.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

By the owner’s will, Myriad-Poison Ring has been transferred to you!
A new Item has become bound to you!
Currently bound Items: White Flame, Myriad-Poison Ring, ???
One bound Item has not yet been given a name. Please give it a new name.

What was with today?

I was starting to get nervous. What kind of fucked-up shit was waiting for me if the System was showering me with rewards like this?

Seeing me open and close my mouth like a goldfish, Tang Sadok smiled faintly.

“If there is anything you desire, tell me. So long as it lies within our family’s power, I will grant it.”

The Divine Physician smiled along with him and answered,

“All I desire is for the patients to recover as soon as possible.”

“Oh?”

An answer worthy of the Divine Physician. Or should I call him Dong Feng now?

One thing was certain: he too was a Divine Physician in every sense of the title.

“What do you desire?”

Cheongpung jumped at the sudden question.

“M-Me?”

Tang Sadok nodded. Cheongpung twisted his hands and feet awkwardly as he answered.

“I… Well… Hmm. Nothing.”

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. I don't think there's anything."

"…"

"…"

Hey, you little bastard. Take your eyes off Mimi-chan[1842] and talk.

I wanted to bring him a mirror and show him what he looked like. His eyes were filled with aching longing and desire for Mimi-chan[1843].

At this rate, he's going to bore a hole through her scales.

Just then, Tang Sadok spoke.

"This little one is an old friend of mine. For the past several decades, she has been the only one with whom I could share the joy, anger, sorrow, and delight I could never reveal to anyone else."

Cheongpung looked at Tang Sadok with pity.

"Grandpa Tang, you don't have any other friends."

"I did not make any. Being the Family Head of the Tang Clan was that kind of position."

"So you don't have any friends."

"It is not that I had none. I could have made them, but…"

"You didn't have a single friend. How sad."

"…"

The Divine Physician hurriedly grabbed Tang Sadok by the shoulder.

"Family Head, calm yourself. You're breathing far too quickly!"

"Huff… Hoo, huff…"

"Take deep, slow breaths. Now, follow me. One, two…"

"Whoooosh…"

After narrowly surviving a bout of high blood pressure, Tang Sadok looked at Cheongpung and spoke.

"But I could entrust Mimi to you…"

Cheongpung covered his mouth with both hands.

"No, Grandpa Tang. I can't take your only friend away from you."

"…I haven't said I would entrust her to you yet."

"Oh. Ohhh."

Tang Sadok let out a deep sigh. For a moment, he had undoubtedly wondered whether it was really safe to entrust Mimi-chan[1844] to someone like that.

"Yes, you guessed correctly. Since we do not know what will become of our family, I wish to entrust Mimi to you. Temporarily, of course."

[1842] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity.

[1843] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity.

[1844] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity.

“Yaaay!”

“Did you hear that last part? Temporarily.”

“Yaaay!”

I’ll bet Hyuk Mujin’s right wrist he didn’t hear it.

Cheongpung was beside himself with joy at becoming Mimi’s temporary guardian.

“Don’t worry. I’ll take good care of her!”

“From what I saw last time, Mimi does seem to follow you well. However, she is naturally quite fussy and very wary of strangers, so…”

“Mimi. Whirlwind, then spin around and around and say hello!”

Sssriririk!

“Oh, shit.”

She busted out a new move right here.

Jin Wikyung, who had been half out of his mind at the sight, muttered in a dazed voice,

“It seems you have nothing to worry about, Family Head.”

An earthquake struck Tang Sadok’s eyes.

Tang Sadok asked Jin Wikyung to remain behind for a private conversation, so Cheongpung and I left the room first.

No—one more person had just been added.

“Young Hero Jin, could you spare this old man a moment?”

“Me?”

The Divine Physician nodded with a gentle smile.

“There is something I must ask of you before you leave.”

Chapter 376

A sea of people.

There was no other way to describe the scene.

Word had spread that the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi—no, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung—and the Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung were leaving, and people had gathered like clouds.

Not only martial artists but fearless ordinary citizens had come to see them off. The crowd stretched on endlessly, one person after another, too many to count.

“Safe travels, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

“Sichuan Murim will never forget you!”

“It has horns! The Huashan Divine Dragon has a horned snake!”

“Whoa! The snake just did a flip in midair!”

“Fire King! The Fire King grabbed the snake and is trying to roast it!”

The murmuring noise gradually faded into the distance as the procession moved away.

On a deserted hill, a boy sat on a tree stump watching the entire scene. Then he suddenly spoke.

“We’ve come a long way.”

“Indeed. I’m getting tired.”

His elderly Disciple dropped heavily onto the grass, breathing hard. Mungyeong murmured,

“…We truly have come a long way.”

He wasn’t talking about distance. Mungyeong was speaking of the years they had traveled together.

“Do you remember when we first met?”

“How could I forget?”

The old Disciple wiped the sweat from his brow as though the scorching sun of that day were beating down on him once more.

“The first year of Hongwu.[1845] That unusually hot summer.”

It was the year the civil war over the imperial throne ended and a new Son of Heaven ascended.

The young, ambitious emperor changed the era name and sought to enact reforms, but the people, exhausted by the long civil war, were too weary to heed the Son of Heaven’s will and take part.

“Rebellions broke out across the land, and bandits ran rampant.”

[1845] Hongwu was the reign name of Zhu Yuanzhang, the founding emperor of China’s Ming dynasty.

“Drought came, and swarms of locusts swept across the plains. The corpses of government soldiers and rebels lay everywhere, and epidemics raged.”

“Yes. It was truly a time of chaos.”

Death begot more death, and before long, it swallowed the continent whole.

A young carpenter surnamed Dong could not escape the dark shadow cast over the land.

“Even now, I sometimes think back to those days.”

The passing decades had changed more than mountains and rivers. The young carpenter who had lost his beloved wife and two children to the epidemic had grown into an old physician.

“I wonder whether I might have saved my family if I had been a little faster. If I had found you sooner.”

“Do you regret it?”

“Yes.”

Sitting on a hill close to the heavens and gazing at wisps of cloud drifting by, the old physician’s eyes became those of the young carpenter once more.

“I will regret it for as long as I draw breath.”

He had been only one day too late.

By the time the carpenter dragged his plague-stricken body to the slash-and-burn settlement and returned with the nameless old physician staying there, it was already over.

He cried for an entire day, then dug a grave for his family. Afterward, he made a single request of the physician he had brought back.

“Please bury me with them. That was what I asked.”

Mungyeong replied bluntly.

“And so I slapped you across the face.”

“It hurt. So much that I wanted to die.”

It hurt. The pain had nothing to do with his life hanging in the balance. It came from knowing he would never see his beloved wife and children again.

“You were the one who helped me back to my feet, Master.”

Mungyeong shook his head.

“I only held out my hand. You chose to take it and rise.”

“I had to live. I had something I needed to do.”

By all rights, the carpenter should have died from the epidemic as well.

But the physician cured him with medical arts unlike anything he had ever seen. For the first time, the carpenter realized that even a mere human could alter the cycle of birth, aging, sickness, and death ordained by Heaven.

“I can still see it clearly. You kneeling before me and begging me to accept you as my Disciple.”

“That differs from what this Disciple remembers. I remember you beckoning for me to follow.”

The young carpenter who had lost his family found a new goal, while the old physician who roamed the land tending to poor and helpless patients gained a new Disciple.

It was only many years later that the carpenter, now a physician named Dong Feng, learned his Master’s true identity.

“The Slaughter Saint… A truly terrifying sobriquet. That was the first time you seemed like a stranger to me, Master.”

Mungyeong gazed impassively into the distance.

What he was about to ask was something he had never once asked his Disciple.

“Why did you not leave?”

“Did you think I would leave you, Master?”

“I have taken more lives than I can count. I was nothing but a hideous Killing Ghost who concealed his past. I would have understood if you had left.”

“Perhaps I might have. But I knew all too well what kind of man you were, Master.”

The next words came softly.

“The Divine Physician. My Master is the man known as the Divine Physician. You would never kill without reason.”

“…!”

Mungyeong’s eyes trembled.

It was a truth he had never told anyone—and one no one had ever been willing to acknowledge.

He had lived as an assassin and personally taken countless lives from the orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction, and the Demonic Cult alike. Every one of them had given him reason to kill them.

A Great Hero of the orthodox faction, renowned for his fairness and integrity, had made a pastime of raping and murdering women. A master of the unorthodox faction had slaughtered an entire village for amusement.

Had the Demonic Cult’s invading armies not killed and destroyed indiscriminately throughout the Central Plains, and had the greatest assassin under Heaven not finally stepped forward to kill its notorious fiends, he could never have become known as the Slaughter Saint.

“If I had not fought the Demonic Cult, the entire world would have pointed fingers at me. Just as it always had.”

The title of Slaughter Saint was merely absolution granted by the orthodox faction once it became the master of Murim—and praise for a powerful man.

Though Mungyeong had always been Mungyeong, people neither knew nor tried to learn the truth hidden behind him.

“Why did you never tell anyone?”

“It is all in the past. I wished to leave Murim, and I became a physician as I intended. That is how I will continue to live.”

Mungyeong slowly rose. By then, the long procession from the Sichuan Tang Clan had already vanished into the distance.

“Let us go down. There are patients waiting for us.”

He spoke in a dry voice and had just taken a step when his Disciple spoke.

“A great war will break out soon.”

Mungyeong stopped dead. Behind him, his elderly Disciple continued.

“What happened back then will happen again. Countless people will die or be wounded. There will be no end to those who lose their parents and children, nor to the screams and death.”

“…We will be very busy. I should make preparations.”

“You know what I am trying to say, Master.”

“I do not wish to know.”

“Master.”

“I am a physician. Though I broke the promise I made to myself and was forced to kill, I will not make the same mistake again.”

Mungyeong continued slowly.

“Fighting is their responsibility, and treating the sick is ours. My heart left Murim long ago.”

“Then why have you never abandoned your martial arts?”

“…!”

Mungyeong was left speechless.

It was a question he himself had harbored for years. If he had wanted to leave Murim because he hated killing, then he should also have abandoned martial arts—the means by which he killed.

Yet his martial arts had advanced even further. Proof that he had been unable to relinquish his attachment to them.

Why?

His elderly Disciple’s voice broke through his brief reverie.

“You can treat hundreds, even thousands of patients, Master. But you are also a man capable of saving tens of thousands of lives at once.”

“…”

“Please prevent this war as the Divine Physician, not the Slaughter Saint. This Disciple will remain here and care for the patients.”

Mungyeong suddenly raised his head and looked at the sky.

Clear and blue.

Seven days earlier, when the Sichuan Tang Clan had been stained with blood, that sky had been filled with dark clouds.

“The sky is clear.”

With those blunt words, Mungyeong resumed walking.

“I should tend to the patients. Take your time coming down.”

Dong Feng’s voice drifted after him as he descended the hill.

“The Hour of the Dog.[1846] They said the ship would depart from Chengdu’s western harbor.”

“Pointless. Murim is not where I belong.”

Yet a faint smile touched the old Disciple’s lips as he watched his Master’s back recede into the distance.

“Please… remain in good health.”

Whoooosh.

A wind blew from somewhere, sweeping between them.

“What are you looking at so intently?”

At Hyuk Mujin’s question, I turned away from the crowd surrounding the harbor.

“Nothing. Just checking, in case.”

“In case of what?”

“You little pest, why are you prying into everything? If I say it’s nothing, just accept that it’s nothing.”

Hyuk Mujin gave me a knowing smile.

“I already know why you’re doing it, Captain.”

“…?”

I froze. How the hell did he know? Even Cheongpung hadn’t heard the conversation between the Divine Physician and me.

Was this guy always this perceptive?

Just as I was wondering, he whispered,

“Weren’t you looking at the Young Lady standing fourth from the right in the front row?”

“…”

“She certainly is pretty. She looks like the daughter of a wealthy family too. If you permit it, Captain, I could go over as your right-hand man and discreetly arrange somewhere private for the two of you…”

“Mujin.”

[1846] The traditional Hour of the Dog lasted roughly from 7 to 9 p.m.

"Yes? Ah, do you prefer meeting naturally? In that case…"

"Do you want to sink to the bottom of the Yangtze?"

"…!"

"Stop spouting bullshit and keep lying there. And don't start puking later because you're seasick."

"…Yes, sir."

As Hyuk Mujin quietly shrank into himself, Gung Gibang snickered.

"You idiot. It wasn't the fourth from the right. It was the third woman from the left. Anyone can see she is much prettier. Your eyes are screwed up."

"Want me to screw up your eyes for you?"

"…Sorry."

"Let's try to live like decent human beings. Decent human beings."

Sighing, I shook my head and swept my gaze over the cloud-like crowd one last time.

They were both definitely pretty, but the third woman from the left was more my type—

No. That wasn't the point.

Damn it. Those bastards kept going on about it, so now I keep looking at her.

As I was thinking that, a huge man with a copper-colored complexion approached me and spoke.

"Hey, Junior. No, not Junior. Young Hero Jin. No, Great Hero."

What is this, buffering?

The man cycling through forms of address at lightning speed was Ship-Fire Boy[1847] Mu Song. I offered him a solution.

"Just call me Junior."

"Ahem. Would that really be all right?"

"Why wouldn't it be? You had no trouble doing it before."

"Still, you have accomplished something extraordinary."

Fair enough. I had gone from a regional young prodigy known as the Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi to a nationally famous figure.

"And Great Hero Jeok does not seem particularly fond of me…"

"It's fine. He's never liked water much to begin with."

Where Mu Song was glancing, Jeok Cheongang stood with his face twisted in fury.

Beside him, Jin Wikyung was examining some bamboo slip whose purpose I couldn't make out, while Cheongpung taught Mimi a new trick.

"Mimi, ride the waves!"

Sssrik, shaaaash!

[1847] Mu Song's sobriquet literally refers to a boy who lights fires aboard a ship.

Was that a water snake?

Distracted for a moment by the rare spectacle, Mu Song finally spoke with an awkward expression.

“Anyway, everything is ready. When should we depart?”

“What time is it?”

“The Hour of the Dog you mentioned has already passed. It would be best to leave before it grows any darker.”

“…Hmm.”

“Are we waiting for someone else?”

I considered Mu Song’s question for a moment, then shook my head.

“No. No one.”

“Then we can depart.”

“Let’s do that.”

“Understood.”

Mu Song raised one hand high, and the river pirates, already fully prepared, moved in perfect unison.

Just as the people gathered to see us off began waving—

“Wait! Wait just a moment!”

“Stop! Stop!”

The bow of the swift ship shuddered as it began pulling away from the harbor.

Far off in the distance, I spotted a boy forcing his way through the crowd. I let out a short laugh.

“Let’s take one more person aboard before we go.”

Chapter 377

“Have they left?”

The Captain of the Guards answered the tense question from the plump, middle-aged City Lord of Sichuan Province.

“Yes. The swift ship of the Yangtze River Channel League carrying them departed half an hour ago.”

“Whew.”

The City Lord let out such a deep sigh of relief that his belly jiggled, then waved a hand.

“All right, you may withdraw. If you hear any news concerning the martial artists, report it immediately.”

“Understood. But what about the troops stationed near Chengdu…?”

The City Lord frowned.

“Listen, Captain of the Guards.”

“Yes?”

“Do I need to concern myself with every trivial detail? Handle that sort of cleanup among yourselves. Consult the Military Commissioner, that stubborn bastard, if you have to. Hmm?”

“…”

The Captain of the Guards was speechless.

Were those words or a fart?

The City Lord’s incompetence and habit of dumping work on his subordinates were nothing new, but this was too much, even for him.

He wasn’t always this bad. Was he?

Several years ago, he had taken a favorite concubine, and ever since then, he had lost himself in carnal pleasures and neglected his official duties.

The Captain of the Guards sighed inwardly and gave a dispirited military salute.

“…I will carry out Your Excellency’s orders.”

“Of course you will. Then get to work. I have an important matter to attend to.”

Only then did the City Lord nod in satisfaction and rise from his seat.

The Captain of the Guards watched his retreating back as he huffed and puffed beneath his excessive weight, then muttered in a voice barely louder than an ant’s.

“Important matter, my ass. He’s probably off to embrace his favorite concubine again.”

The Captain of the Guards’ prediction was correct. The first place the City Lord visited after leaving the great hall was a lavishly decorated bedchamber.

“Aehyang! Aehyang!”

A beauty lying half-naked on a silk bed larger than most rooms sat up.

“My lord. Why did you take so long? Aehyang has been waiting for you.”

“Y-You have?”

The City Lord was dazed once by her coy eyes and twice by the snow-white skin peeking through the sheets. His mouth fell open in a foolish grin.

“I’m sorry. The Captain of the Guards kept bothering me.”

“That man again? My lord is already so busy. Why does he keep harassing you?”

“I know, right?”

“This is why incompetent underlings are such a problem. Without my lord, none of them could do anything.”

“You’re the only one who truly understands me, Aehyang!”

It was the sort of conversation that would have made the Captain of the Guards roll his eyes if he had heard it.

As the City Lord’s cheeks trembled with emotion, his favorite concubine opened both arms toward him.

“Come here, my lord. You’ve worked so hard. Let Aehyang hold you.”

“Aehyang…”

At the seductive smile lingering in his beloved concubine’s eyes, the City Lord’s gaze grew hazy.

“Could there possibly be a woman in all the world as beautiful as you?”

The City Lord had been born into a powerful family that had produced members of the Three Excellencies[1848] and had enjoyed a smooth path through life.

Backed by inexhaustible wealth, he had visited pleasure houses countless times and held every kind of beauty in his arms.

He had taken several women as concubines whenever they caught his fancy. But after meeting so many women, his interest in each had always faded within a year.

But this girl is different!

He swore he had never seen a woman like her. Her voice, her gaze, even the slightest movement of her fingertips—everything about Aehyang was enchanting and lovable in the City Lord’s eyes.

Even after several years, he never tired of the sight of her. No—if anything, he was sinking deeper under her spell, almost frighteningly so.

“I love you. I love you, Aehyang!”

The City Lord, who had just entered his fifties, cried out with the passion of a young man in love.

As though bewitched, he approached and nestled into his favorite concubine’s embrace. As he always did, he began telling her about everything that had

[1848] The Three Excellencies were the highest-ranking offices in the imperial government.

happened that day. To the City Lord, she was the only person to whom he could confide even his most intimate secrets.

"…And so, those troublesome ruffians finally left."

"You mean those people, don't you? The martial artists who came here last time."

"That's right. The ones who brought His Highness Prince Shangshan's Token."

"Hmm."

"What is it?"

"Nothing. I was just thinking that you must have had such a difficult time because of this. I heard the martial artists got into a fight and many people were killed or injured."

The City Lord shook his head in disgust.

"Don't remind me. They dared to steal government uniforms from who knows where, put them on, and disrupt the order of the Great Nation."

"Oh my. Is that true?"

"You may find it hard to believe, but it is. Whatever else happens, I must submit a report to the imperial court about this…"

"How gallant of you. But, my lord…"

With a sweet smile, Aehyang stroked the City Lord's head where it rested on her lap.

"Wouldn't this become a serious matter if the imperial court found out?"

"H-Hmm?"

"Think about it. One day, my lord will rise to become one of the Three Excellencies[1849], command all the civil and military officials, and assist the Emperor… I'm worried that the people who envy you might use this incident against you."

"Heh heh. You truly are the only one who cares so much about me, Aehyang."

The City Lord gazed at his favorite concubine with overflowing affection.

But he was not a complete fool.

Though the government and Murim occupied mutually noninterfering spheres and generally regarded each other as none of their concern, well over a thousand people had died throughout Sichuan over the past seven days and nights.

He could leave the trivial cleanup to his subordinates, but this was something he needed to handle personally.

"Your concern is admirable, but the bigger the matter, the more trouble it causes if you try to hide it."

"My lord, do you really think I don't know that?"

"Hmm? Then what do you suggest?"

[1849]The Three Excellencies were the highest-ranking offices in the imperial government.

“Hide what must be hidden and exaggerate your accomplishments.”

Her coquettish voice tickled the City Lord’s ear.

“Say that there was a major conflict among the martial artists and that my lord mobilized the government troops under your command to bring the situation under control.”

“Hmm.”

“You will become a benevolent City Lord who restored the Great Nation’s order after it was disrupted by ruffians and cared for the common people. Of course, it would be best to leave out the part about the government weapons and uniforms. They might cause misunderstandings.”

“It would be nice if things went exactly as you say, Aehyang. But even so, submitting a false report to the court…”

“My lord, look at me.”

The hesitant City Lord let out a short exclamation when he saw her eyes, beautiful and gleaming like polished obsidian.

“Ah.”

“Do you not understand how I feel about you, my lord? How much I adore you?”

“I… That is…”

The City Lord could not finish his sentence.

The moment his eyes met his concubine’s, his mind had already gone blank.

His heart trembled at her alluring figure, and the flowerlike fragrance of her body made his senses swim.

An immense trust and affection that had risen from somewhere, along with unbearable desire, seized control of him.

“Aehyang, Aehyang!”

His voice was desperate. But his concubine caught the City Lord’s hand as it reached out to grope her body.

“My lord, what is your answer?”

“Of course I’ll do as you say. I’ll do anything for you!”

The smile on his concubine’s lips deepened.

“Well done. Just keep doing as you have until now. Do you understand?”

“Yes, yes!”

Overcome by intense desire, the City Lord failed to notice the ominous sight of an eerie red light seeping into the eyes of the concubine he loved so deeply.

“Oh, what a good boy. Our City Lord listens so well.”

His favorite concubine let out a peal of laughter.

Everything was proceeding exactly as she wanted—or rather, as that person wanted.

“Hmm?”

“What is it?”

“Nothing. I thought I heard some crazy bitch laughing just now.”

“A crazy woman? Here?”

“Yeah. It gave me a bad feeling.”

Hyuk Mujin and I looked around. Three swift ships flying the flags of the Water Dragon Stronghold were gliding unhindered along a broad tributary of the Yangtze, and naturally, there was not a woman aboard any of them.

“Did I hear wrong? That’s strange.”

After everything I’ve been through lately, am I hallucinating now?

As I pondered the question, Hyuk Mujin spoke with a serious expression.

“Could it be that…”

“That what?”

“You have been unable to forget the Young Lady standing fourth from the right in the front row?”

Gung Gibang shook his head.

“Bullshit. It was the third from the left. A beauty like that would be hard to forget.”

“Oh, so that’s what this was about?”

I smiled benevolently at the two of them.

“I think today is going to be a day neither of you will ever forget.”

Still smiling brightly, I beckoned. Several burly river pirates came running over and bowed repeatedly.

“Did you call for us, Great Hero Jin?”

“Is there something you need these humble servants to do?”

“Grab those two bastards and give them a little dip in the Yangtze.”

The river pirates stared back in confusion.

“Uh, did you say a dip?”

“We’re ignorant men, I’m afraid. What exactly does ‘dip’ mean?”

“Dipping is the proper culture[1850]… No, I mean just keep dunking their heads in the water and pulling them back out until I tell you to stop.”

“Ohhh, understood.”

“That sounds easy enough.”

“W-Wait a minute!”

“Captain!”

[1850] This refers to the Korean debate over *jjikmeok*, dipping food into sauce, versus pouring sauce over it.

Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang tried to resist, but it was hopeless.

One had only one good leg, while the other was wrapped in bandages from head to toe.

As several hulking, martial-arts-trained river pirates swarmed them, seized their arms and legs, and began the dunking show, I turned my attention to the System Window I had already left floating in the air.

SYSTEM

There is a bound Item that has not yet been named. Would you like to inspect it?

Obviously, yes.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
???
Type: Armor
Grade: Divine Weapon
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Description: A suit of armor containing the spirit of an unknown ancient master smith. It possesses truly formidable defensive power. With its former owner dead, it has become bound to a new owner. Once given a name, it can be freely used anywhere.

It became bound to me because its former owner died?

I had suspected as much, and it seemed the Item was exactly what I thought it was.

After turning my inventory upside down, I found the new bound Item. A flat, deflated sound escaped me.

"...To me?"

The thing resting on my palm was nothing more than a tiny fragment. It had once been called the Black Dragon Armor.

I definitely blasted it away along with that bastard, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, in the final One Annihilation. Did it automatically enter my inventory because it was a bound Item?

I could still vividly see the Black Dragon Armor shattering into pieces.

But I had no idea what I was supposed to do with a fragment this small.

I'd certainly feel safe with this tucked down the front of my underwear.

Ah. Was that why it was classified as armor?

I had just tugged at the front of my pants to check the most suitable position when —

“What are you doing—”

“…Ah.”

A chilly silence descended over the scene.

The boy’s face stiffened when he saw my loosened waistband and my hand shoved inside it.

After making sure no one else was nearby, the Slaughter Saint—no, Mungyeong—spoke.

“Of all places, here?”

“No, wait. I think there’s been a misunderstanding.”

I was about to hurriedly explain when Mungyeong’s gaze turned cold.

“I told you before we departed. In front of anyone other than the Fire King and Cheongpung, you are to treat me as Mungyeong.”

I answered with an aggrieved expression.

“You’re speaking informally too, asshole.”

“…!”

“Ah. Sorry.”

Mungyeong wore an expression of mixed emotions, then clicked his tongue as he glanced at the river pirates approaching us.

The terrifying Slaughter Saint transformed into the Divine Physician’s Disciple and a cheerful young medical apprentice in an instant.

“What were you doing?”

“What business is it of yours?”

“…!”

This was surprisingly fun. But I couldn’t do it three times.

I quickly held out my hand toward the speechless Mungyeong.

“This got into the waistband of my pants.”

That was not entirely true, of course, but Mungyeong did not care about any of that. More precisely, his gaze was fixed on the fragment of the Black Dragon Armor.

“This is…”

“Do you happen to know this Item? No, do you recognize it?”

“Where did you get it?”

“From that guy.”

Mungyeong understood that I meant the Western Heaven Demon Lord and nodded.

“You acquired a Divine Weapon. I do not know how only a fragment came to remain, though.”

“He called it the Black Dragon Armor.”

“The Black Dragon Armor?”

“What? Is that different from the name you knew?”

“I read about it in an old secret history. It spoke of a mysterious suit of armor with no fixed name, whose form and properties changed according to its owner.”

“Its form and properties change? How?”

Mungyeong answered with a look that suggested I was an idiot.

Only then did I realize what I needed to do.

Internal energy.

An owner’s internal energy embodied their form and nature.

Ssshhh.

Following the formula of the eighth-stage Fire Gate Divine Technique, I sent lava-like energy flowing toward the fragment of the Black Dragon Armor.

The ink-black energy swirling over the fragment’s surface disappeared, and bluish-white Scorching Yang Qi filled its place.

Now engraved with a pattern resembling blazing flames, the object could no longer be called the Black Dragon Armor.

Fire Dragon Armor.

It was simple, but there could be no more fitting name.

The moment I smiled in satisfaction, a cheerful chime rang out.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have given the bound Item ??? a new name!
You can now freely use Fire Dragon Armor anywhere!
Fire Dragon Armor is resonating with your energy! It seeks its owner’s strength to repair its damaged sections on its own!

Whoosh.

I could feel the vast amount of internal energy leaving my body and rushing toward the Fire Dragon Armor.

I pretended to tuck the energy-draining object into my arms before storing it in my inventory.

Automatic repair? That’s incredible.

I had definitely acquired something useful.

Thank goodness the last gift I received on this journey was the Fire Dragon Armor.

Mungyeong stared at me with wide eyes as I turned away.

“Where are you go—where are you headed?”

“What business is it of yours?”

“…!”

I was starting to think I might get addicted to this.

I waved at Mungyeong, who was probably repeating the character for patience in his head.

“I’m going to take a nap. Don’t wake me.”

“…?”

Yes. Now it was time to awaken from a long sleep.

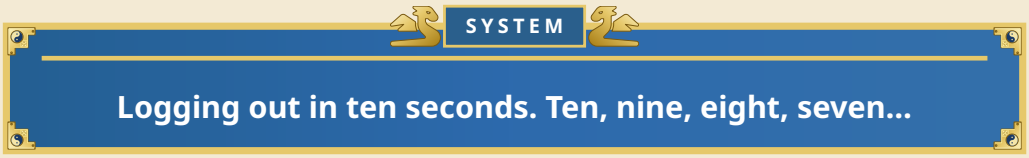
But…

Why do I feel so uneasy? Did I forget something?

Frowning, I found a place in the swift ship’s cabin and lay down. I closed my eyes, drew a deep breath, and spoke the command.

Logout.

Ding.

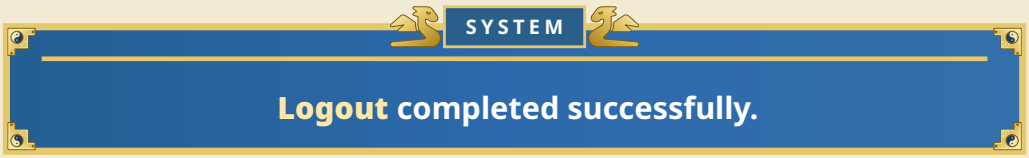


With the final count, the sound of splashing water and someone’s distant cries seeped faintly into my ears.

Splash! Gasp! “Captain, save—” Gasp!

Chapter 378

Ding.



With the cheerful System notification, the senses that had briefly fallen away began to return.

The softness of the bed against my back. The warm air inside the private jet.

And the hands gripping and shaking both my shoulders, along with someone's shouting.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung! Wake up! Mr. Jin Taekyung!"

—Wake up, you wicked human!

At the two urgent voices drilling into my ears—no, the voices of one monster and one human—I blinked.

As my vision cleared, a familiar face came into view.

"Uh, Team Leader Choi…"

Smack!

"Wake up!"

—Well done, you slightly less wicked human!

"…"

What the hell?

Stunned by the completely unexpected slap, I answered in a daze.

"I'm awake…"

"What is wrong with you?! We've been trying to wake you up! Why are you only getting up now?!"

—Just die! Go ahead and die!

"S-Sorry…"

Talk about forceful. This was the first time I had ever seen Team Leader Choi this furious.

Lightning practically shot from the eyes of the man who stayed calm no matter what happened and spent his time showing off designer goods.

But what's gotten into him? We're still on the plane, aren't we?

I had apologized reflexively, but I was still bewildered. Was this really enough to earn a slap?

Then—

"This is no time for this! Hurry—"

“Aaaah!”

The rest of Team Leader Choi’s words were drowned out by the flight attendants’ screams. Shouts from men I assumed were the pilots followed.

“Mayday! Mayday! Mayday!”

“Control tower! Control toweeer!”

“…What the fuck?”

What the hell was happening?

As I frantically looked around, Team Leader Choi dropped a bombshell.

“We’re under attack by monsters!”

“Monsters? An attack?”

What kind of bullshit was that? We were flying at twenty-five thousand feet in a private jet sent by China’s Central Committee.

By now, it wouldn’t have been strange to see our destination, Chengdu International Airport in Sichuan Province—

“Huh?”

I absentmindedly turned my head to look out the window, then stared with my mouth hanging open.

Far below, flames surged from the sprawling airport while dots of every size moved across the grounds.

It was a battle. Humans and monsters were fighting each other to the death.

And that wasn’t all.

—Kyaoo-o-o-o!

A gigantic monster was rapidly closing in on our private jet.

That’s…

There was no mistaking it. Even after rubbing my eyes and looking again, it was a Wyvern.

An A-rank monster classified as dragonkin alongside the Drake.

They were bastards I wouldn’t want to meet even on the ground, let alone at twenty-five thousand feet.

And there were more than ten of them!

…What kind of fucked-up situation is this?

A fierce battle raged around Chengdu International Airport below, while a pack of Wyverns pursued our private jet at twenty-five thousand feet.

It didn’t take my temporarily frozen brain long to reach a conclusion.

“Lich!”

The name burst from my mouth like lightning.

A week ago in the modern world, the apex undead monster had appeared alongside an unprecedented monster wave. It had undoubtedly extended its sinister reach all the way here.

“The control tower isn’t responding!”

“The Wyverns, the Wyverns…”

“Kyaaaah!”

—I knew this would happen! We’re all as good as dead!

Even in my panic, I corrected the Skeleton Warlord.

“That’s true, but weren’t you already dead?”

—Shut up, you wicked human! This is all your fault! Ahhh, my legion! Forgive your commander!

Human and monster alike, everyone was panicking. Screams and shouts erupted from every direction.

Only one person among them retained any semblance of sanity.

“Everyone, calm down! Nothing you’re worried about is going to happen!”

As expected of Team Leader Choi. Reliable as ever. He must have thought of a way out of this crisis.

After calming everyone with his steady voice, Team Leader Choi pointed at me.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung will handle it!”

“…”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, what should we do?”

“Wait, why are you asking me…?”

“I believe in you, Mr. Jin Taekyung!”

“…”

That was exactly the problem. Why did he believe in me? In a situation like this, believing in God, Buddha, or Allah would probably do him more good.

For a moment, I lost my ability to speak. Then the gazes of everyone around me flew toward me and pierced into my body.

“N-Now that you mention it, I’ve heard about that Hunter. They say he’s so capable that even Comrade Chairman Xiao Yang made a special request for him.”

“I’ve heard the rumors too. They say he might be a new S-rank Hunter. Apparently, he defeated two Named Monsters all by himself.”

“Ooh! Oooooh!”

“We’re saved! We’re going to live!”

—You, wicked human! I knew you were strong, but this is beyond anything I imagined! Rejoice, my legion. Your commander lives!

“…I already told you, you’re dead.”

This was driving me insane. None of them were in their right minds anymore.

I stared at Team Leader Choi in disbelief.

“What exactly are you basing this on?”

Team Leader Choi answered without hesitation.

“I already told you. I believe in you.”

“That’s what I’m asking. Where is this baseless faith coming from—”

“It isn’t baseless.”

“Excuse me?”

“The way you’re acting in a situation like this. Your tone. Your expression. All of it gives me reason to believe in you.”

“…!”

Only then did I realize the truth.

The unexpected situation had caught me off guard, but I wasn’t afraid. I didn’t feel the slightest trace of fear or dread.

The answer was closer than I had thought.

Because I’m strong.

I was strong. Stronger than before. Strong enough to avoid any danger.

That was why I wasn’t afraid of the monsters sweeping across the ground like a wave, or the pack of Wyverns closing in right behind us.

“So that’s what it is…”

I muttered under my breath, then spoke up.

“Who’s the captain?”

A hand suddenly shot up from the cockpit ahead.

It was trembling violently. The captain was probably using his other hand to clutch the controls for dear life and desperately evade the Wyverns bearing down on us.

“I-I am.”

“Can I open the door for a moment?”

“What?”

“I’m asking if I can open the plane door.”

The question must have shocked him senseless, because he poked his head out and stared at me like I was insane.

“Of course not! The pressure-sealing system won’t even let you open it, and the aircraft would be damaged by the pressure difference! You wouldn’t be able to breathe properly either!”

Team Leader Choi fiddled with the ring on his finger and cut in.

“I think I can block the pressure. I don’t know what you have in mind, but give it a try.”

“Okay.”

"Don't! You *bangzi* bastards! Are you trying to kill us all?!"

"…What, *bangzi*?"[1851]

How dare he insult Koreans in front of a proud Korean Kimchi Man?

The captain's face went pale when he realized what had slipped out.

"No, that's not what I meant."

"You chink bastard. Damn it."

"…!"

"Hey, Captain!"

"Y-Yes?"

"Should I open it?"

"Ah! Aah!"

Before the captain could stop me, I opened the door.

No—I cut it open.

Slice!

Force—the phenomenon known as an Aura Blade in the modern world—sliced through the sturdy alloy, creating a small opening.

It was the kind of overwhelming power only a Supreme Peak master could display in Murim, or an S-rank Hunter here.

Team Leader Choi's eyes widened in shock.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, this is…!"

"Team Leader!"

Whoooosh!

This was no time to stand around gawking. The tremendous wind and pressure had sent the aircraft lurching and thrown the cabin into chaos.

The passengers' screams and my shout brought Team Leader Choi back to his senses. He rubbed his ring.

"A flawless barrier surrounds us. Barrier!"

"Oh."

Along with the incantation, a transparent mana barrier blocked the new opening without leaving so much as a gap.

So that was one way to do it.

With a brief exclamation of admiration, I stuck my upper body outside the cabin.

Team Leader Choi's Barrier spell recognized me as an ally and let me pass through without resistance.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The wind pressure battered my upper body as if trying to crush me to death. I grinned.

[1851] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans.

This is no joke.

But it wasn't unbearable.

No, it would have been stranger if I couldn't endure it. Compared to the waves of energy the Western Heaven Demon Lord had unleashed, this was no more than a gentle spring breeze.

—Kyaoo-o-o-o!

A monster's shrill cry mingled with that spring breeze.

The pack of Wyverns had already drawn close. I judged the distance between us.

About a hundred meters.[1852] *I've never tried this before…but at this distance, it should be enough.*

Inventory, open. Equip.

Sssshk.

A spear I'd bought at a discount from the Hunter Market slid into my hand.

Like a javelin thrower, I drew my shoulder as far back as it would go. From my waist to my wrist, every necessary muscle and tendon pulled taut like a bowstring.

—Kyaoo!

Sensing something was wrong, the leader Wyvern at the front shrieked and threw back its head.

I could see a mass of pure-white air being sucked toward its snout.

That's…

—Breath! It's using Breath! Dodge it, wicked human!

The Skeleton Warlord was right.

Of all the countless monsters in existence, Breath was a power granted only to the dragonkin. I could clearly see it taking shape inside the Wyvern's gaping maw.

Gooooom.

A gigantic sphere of wind. The instant the Air Breath, powerful enough to shred metal like paper, fully took shape—

"Hey, Wyvern!"

—Kyaoo?

"I'm putting it in!"

With a thunderous shout, I whipped my drawn-back shoulder forward.

Fwoosh! Sssshaaa!

Flaming Force enveloped the spearhead, scorching the air and slicing through the wind.

The Wyvern's bright-yellow eyes widened as the blue-white streak of light shot straight toward it.

—Kiiiiik!

[1852] A hundred meters is about 330 ft.

Whoooosh!

Compressed air erupted from the spear’s tip. A pure-white cloud burst outward, and then—

Crunch! Boom-boom!

The gigantic body plummeted toward the ground like a kite with its string cut.

—Kyaoo?

—Kiiit?

More than ten pairs of bright-yellow eyes looked at one another.

Wyverns were ferocious from the moment they were born, but right now, they were so bewildered that they had no idea what to do.

—Kikik?

—Kiiik…

What? Is the boss dead?

I think so…

After exchanging words among themselves, the Wyverns were dumbfounded.

Their leader had been exceptional even among its own kind, powerful enough to earn the name “Black Star.”

And now, the Black Star had become a black dot plummeting toward the distant ground.

—Kiririk?

—Grrrrk.

None of them had even gotten a proper look at how it died.

They could only guess that the tiny human had thrown a spear and struck it.

But that was absurd.

How could a mere human dare to attack a descendant of the great dragon—

“Hey, Green Wyvern!”

—Kik?

“I’m putting it in!”

Crunch!

This time, they saw it clearly.

Their comrade’s head burst apart in the streak of light.

—Kik!

—Kyaoo-o-o!

After their leader, another of their bloodline had died!

The enraged Wyverns swore revenge on that accursed human.

—Kiiit!

Of course, not today.
They would take revenge later. A little later.
“Hey, Blue Wyvern!”
Crunch!
…Could they actually get their revenge?
More than ten pairs of wings began flapping for dear life.

Chapter 379

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

A tremendous roar shook the air, while vibrations traveled through the ground.

Xiao Shen stared toward the horizon, unable to believe what was happening.

The monsters are supposed to be thousands of kilometers away.[1853] *How did they…?*

The twenty-year-old was not the only one wondering.

More than a thousand Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department and five thousand members of the Chinese People's Liberation Army had been dispatched to Chengdu International Airport to maintain public order. Every one of them had the same question, and every one of them was stunned by the reality bearing down on them.

—Screeech!

—Graaaar!

From low-level monsters such as goblins and Orcs to higher-tier monsters like Trolls, ogres, and Lycanthropes…

An army of monsters filled the horizon, charging forward with hideous shrieks.

The one-kilometer gap[1854] was closing by the second. Panicked cries rang out.

"Form ranks by unit! Assemble! Form up—!"

"Fire! Fire!"

Rat-a-tat-tat! Boom!

The People's Liberation Army hurriedly formed ranks and unleashed their firepower at their commanders' orders, but the effect was negligible.

No one had expected an army of monsters to attack.

The soldiers were ordinary people without any special abilities. Fear paralyzed them, and their weapons were effective only against low-level monsters at best.

"There are too many! There are too many monsters!"

"Pilots!"

"Get the fighter jets in the air! Bomb them from above—!"

The commanders' frantic shouts were drowned out by a ferocious roar from the sky.

—Kyaaaao-o-o!

"W-What is that?"

"Wyvern! It's a Wyvern!"

A gigantic shape flew toward them with the setting sun at its back.

[1853] Thousands of kilometers means at least about 2,000 km, or about 1,200 mi.

[1854] One kilometer is about 0.62 mi.

A Wyvern, known as the terror of the skies, led the charge, followed by dozens of Griffons and Gargoyles.

The A-rank monsters angled their wings, each several meters long,[1855] and dove upon the fighter jets that had yet to take off.

Crunch! Boom!

Their powerful wingbeats rocked the several-ton machines,[1856] while magical-power-infused claws tore through the aircraft hulls like paper.

Metal fragments blasted outward with tremendous force, mowing down the pilots running frantically toward their planes.

Boom! Crunch!

They died instantly, without even the chance to scream.

The commanders regained their senses and ordered the soldiers to open fire, but even hundreds—thousands—of bullets left no more than scratches on the monsters' magical-power-infused skin and hides.

—Kikikik.

The monsters laughed at the helpless humans.

A shock of terror swept through the soldiers, making every hair on their bodies stand on end.

"H-How can this be?"

An army of monsters filled the ground and sky. Even firearms barely affected them.

They were monsters in every sense of the word.

"M-Monsters…"

"I-I have to live. I don't want to die like a dog in a place like this!"

The fear of death spread faster than any epidemic.

As the People's Liberation Army began backing away, one person strode forward instead.

"Don't retreat!"

Xiao Shen shouted, his youthful face still not quite rid of its boyishness and his eyes blazing.

The Five-Starred Red Flag, the national flag of the People's Republic of China, was emblazoned across the chest of his armor.

"Who are we?"

Those who had been about to flee stopped in their tracks at the young man's question.

Xiao Shen glared at the army of monsters charging from several hundred meters

---

[1855] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

[1856] A metric ton is 1,000 kg, or about 2,200 lb.

away.[1857] His voice thundered once more from beneath his low-pulled helmet.

“Who are we?”

The shout made their blood boil.

With every eye upon him, Xiao Shen raised his spearhead high.

“We are the descendants of Zhonghua![1858] We are brothers of the People’s Liberation Army and the Public Security Armed Forces Department!”

Aura the color of sunset blazed from the spearhead thrust toward the heavens.

Hissss!

“Let’s go! Let’s wipe out every last one of those monsters!”

“Waaaaaaah!”

A tremendous roar numbed the ears and shook the earth.

Led by Xiao Shen, the Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department gripped their weapons and charged the monster army like ferocious tigers.

“Don’t retreat! Show them the strength of Zhonghua!”

“Uaaaaah!”

—Graaaar!

—Awooooo!

Human cries filled with the resolve to face death mingled with the monsters’ shrieks. The two groups collided and became entangled in one mass.

Kwagwagwagwang!

The collision shook heaven and earth. Death rained down from every direction.

“Gyaaaah!”

—Kweeeek!

Squish! Crack!

Screams and thunderous impacts rang out across the battlefield.

An A-rank Hunter’s aura-coated blade sliced through a Lycanthrope’s neck, while a single swing of an ogre’s iron club reduced three or four Hunters to bloody pulp and sent them flying.

Two Hunters combined their strength to bring down a monster. As they raised their weapons against their next foe, a gigantic shadow fell over them.

—Kiiiiiit!

Slice!

A Griffon plunged from the sky, its claws shredding the Hunters’ bodies along with their armor.

As it searched for its next prey, a large ball of fire hurtled toward it.

“Fire Ball!”

[1857] Several hundred meters is roughly 200–900 m, or about 660–3,000 ft.

[1858] *Zhonghua* is a Chinese term for China and Chinese civilization.

Boom!

The Griffon's body reeled amid the acrid smoke. The ranged units on the ground had been watching for just such an opportunity, and they did not let it pass.

"Now!"

Bang! Boom-boom-boom!

All manner of spells and arrows brimming with mana pierced the Griffon.

It plummeted with a dying shriek, and the other flying monsters let loose ferocious cries.

—Kyaaaao-o-o!

Modern weapons made of lead and iron blocked the flying monsters as they plunged toward the ranged units.

"Concentrated fire!"

Rat-a-tat-tat-tat! Boom!

Countless rifles and heavy weapons opened fire. Dozens of tanks unleashed their cannons at once.

Modern weapons could not compare to mana, the natural counter to a monster's magical power, but so much concentrated fire still forced the flying monsters to falter.

—Kiiit!

"It's working!"

"Anywhere else is useless! Aim for their eyes!"

The flesh of monsters, saturated with magical power from birth, easily shrugged off most physical force.

But there was one exception: the eyes.

Covered only by a thin membrane, their eyeballs could be damaged by heavy weapons.

At the sight of the monsters hesitating, the divisional commander who had been watching the battle excitedly waved his command baton.

"More! Pour it on! Pin those monsters down—"

Rooooar!

His voice cut off.

Poison Breath from a Green Wyvern blanketed an area over a hundred meters in radius.[1859] The divisional commander and his command staff were drenched in powerful acidic poison and melted away.

"C-Commander!"

"The command staff…!"

[1859] A hundred meters is about 330 ft.

The People's Liberation Army lost hundreds of soldiers and high-ranking officers in the blink of an eye. Panic swept through its ranks.

Officers, noncommissioned officers, and enlisted soldiers alike stared at the horrific scene before them, crying out in shock.

"This can't be happening…"

"N-No. This isn't right. It can't be! This isn't my mission!"

That scream spoke for all of them.

They had deployed in force as a precaution, but their primary mission was to meet and escort the foreign Hunters arriving at Chengdu International Airport, then follow their superiors' orders.

No one had said anything about an army of monsters thousands of kilometers away[1860] invading the airport.

"What the hell is happening…?"

"We're going to die. We're all going to die."

The fear they had briefly forgotten descended upon the People's Liberation Army once more.

They were not the Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department fighting at the front. They were only ordinary people carrying modern firearms.

And their ominous suspicion soon became reality.

A nightmare worse than anything they had imagined.

—Om. Neu. Ha. So. Yu.

A voice spoke in broken, disconnected syllables. The eerie sound, like static from a radio with a poor signal, echoed across the battlefield.

Black fog that had gathered from somewhere spread over the people's heads.

—Yen. Wi. Ga. Ji. Ke!

That was when the horrific change occurred.

Swoooosh!

Dark magical power, black as storm clouds, spread through the blood and corpses like a spiderweb.

It breathed new power and souls into the bodies growing cold, binding and subjugating them with chains.

Crack. Crack-crack-crack.

An army of skeletons slowly rose from pools of death, granted new life.

Those beings bound the countless dead with invisible chains and made them their slaves.

They laughed in satisfaction.

—Kik, kikikik.

[1860] Thousands of kilometers means at least about 2,000 km, or about 1,200 mi.

—Grrk. Kihihih.

—Grrrrrk.

With a bubbling sound, a man rose to his feet.

Clad in armor emblazoned with the Five-Starred Red Flag and carrying a massive ax, he looked exactly like the A-rank Hunter Xiao Shen remembered.

…Mr. Yao Wei.

But Xiao Shen could not say the man's name aloud.

He could not bring himself to.

Because he knew that the person standing before him was no longer the man he had known.

Ah… ahhh.

If Xiao Shen had not witnessed his decapitation a little over ten minutes earlier—if the man had not risen with his own severed head tucked under one arm—he would still have thought of him as a colleague and friend.

But Yao Wei no longer existed.

His new name slipped from Xiao Shen's lips.

"Dullahan…"

A headless knight.

A Dullahan.

Xiao Shen bit his lip at the sight of his former colleague transformed into a high-level undead monster. Something hot ran down his cheek.

"I'm sorry. I truly am."

—Graaaar!

The Dullahan charged with a shriek.

Xiao Shen shot forward like the wind.

The two of them had often sparred like this. What began as simple competitive pride became a daily routine, and after every bout, Xiao Shen had to endure Yao Wei's complaints.

You little punk. Where are your manners? Would it kill you to let me win once?

Ha-ha. Let's go get something to eat. The loser pays, so I guess you're buying again today, Mr. Yao Wei.

You've got plenty of money at home, and you're still so greedy. One day, I'll make you buy me a meal.

But that had never happened, and now it never would.

Xiao Shen had always won.

Goodbye. Thank you for everything.

Whoosh! Slice!

The ax cleaved through empty air.

Aura blazed from Xiao Shen's spearhead and tore through the Dullahan's torso from the waist. The headless knight slowly crumpled.

Thud. Crash.

Xiao Shen stared down at the face of the fallen Dullahan—no, Yao Wei—and his eyes burned.

"How dare you… How dare you do this…"

Only half a day ago, these friends and colleagues had been laughing and talking with him.

Now they were undead monsters.

The Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department were famous for their strict discipline, but they were not cold-blooded people without a drop of blood in their veins.

They had entered battle prepared to die. Now, for the first time, they faced the fear born of their attachment to one another.

"Get a grip! It's me, Liu Yinqin! Liu Yinqin!"

"H-Hyung…!"[1861]

—Grrrrrk!

Crack! Boom!

Screams and death rained down from every direction.

The Public Security Armed Forces Department had lost nearly half its strength. The monster army, on the other hand, had only grown in number and continued pouring forward without end.

Am I going to die here, like this?

For the first time in his life, Xiao Shen contemplated his own death.

The situation was desperate enough to make even someone as bright and cheerful as him think that way.

We never received a warning signal, so communications are probably down. There won't be any reinforcements either… This really is the end.

Slice!

Xiao Shen cut down one charging undead monster after another, then laughed hollowly and looked up at the sky.

The sunset was beautiful.

Once the sun went down and darkness came, he would never see a sight like it again.

At least the last sky I see isn't half bad…

[1861] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a younger man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

Huh?
Xiao Shen blinked, his thought cut short.
Something enormous was hurtling toward the battlefield from high above.
An airplane?
Roooooar!
A gigantic aircraft wreathed in flames.
Then someone’s shout rang across the vast sky.
“Hey! Monsters!”
“…”
—…?
Am I hearing things?
Not only Xiao Shen but everyone on the battlefield looked up.
Someone’s voice, carrying an almost palpable madness, rang out like thunder.
“I’m going to ram it!”
Ram what?
Xiao Shen soon understood.
Rumble, rumble, rumble!
The airplane’s enormous fuselage plowed straight across the battlefield.

Chapter 380

Xiao Shen realized something for the first time.

Roooooar!

The sight of an airplane diving toward the ground with both wings engulfed in flames inspired terror that transcended species.

—Graaaar!

The supposedly ferocious ogres and Trolls screamed.

—Gweeeaaah!

Even the notoriously sluggish Ghouls ran hard enough to work up a sweat on the soles of their feet.

—Squeeeeee!

“Uh, uh, uhhh…”

The monsters capable of screaming were the lucky ones.

Xiao Shen and most of the others could only stand frozen like statues, staring at the airplane hurtling toward the ground.

I have to run…

His hands and feet refused to move.

More importantly, Xiao Shen and the Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department were surrounded in the middle of the battlefield. They had no chance to escape.

Is this really the end?

The same thought crossed everyone’s mind at that moment.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

With a deafening roar, the airplane’s enormous fuselage swept across the battlefield.

The earth-shaking collision began at the rear of the monster army as it scattered like a swarm of ants.

Crunch! Crack!

The massive steel hulk, weighing dozens of tons[1862], crushed and burst apart everything in its path.

Green monster blood sprayed like fountains, and limbs of every size flew in all directions.

W-What the hell is this…?

No matter how powerful the monsters’ physical defenses were, they had their limits. Nothing could stop the airplane now that it had transformed into a monster blender.

[1862] A metric ton is 1,000 kg, or about 2,200 lb.

—Graaaar…!

—Kiiiiek!

Krrrunch!

The monsters’ screams vanished beneath the grisly sounds of flesh being torn apart. It was a scene of carnage beyond anything they had ever seen or heard.

As Xiao Shen and the Hunters stared blankly at the unimaginable sight, someone’s frenzied shout pierced their ears.

“Monsters! Ram them! Kill them!”

“…!”

Even amid all this chaos, they could clearly hear their native language. A single word flashed through the minds of the Public Security Armed Forces Department Hunters.

Reinforcements.

Xiao Shen was stunned.

An incredible powerhouse!

The voice carried tremendous mana. The speaker was unquestionably an S-rank Hunter.

“Go for it! Airplaaaaane!”

“…”

And unquestionably a slightly insane S-rank Hunter.

To think he’d resort to a tactic those island bastards used in World War II. Did he not consider that his own allies might die?

He seems to have been sent by the Central Military Commission… But did our country have an S-rank Hunter like that?

The question suddenly occurred to Xiao Shen, but it was about to become irrelevant.

The gigantic steel hulk that had ground its way across half the battlefield was now charging straight toward him and the other Hunters.

—K-Kiiit!

“Run!”

There was no distinction between friend and foe in the struggle to survive.

Forgetting the humans right in front of him, Xiao Shen drove his dagger into a monster that barreled into him.

Schunk!

—Grrrk.

The monster’s lifeless body collapsed toward Xiao Shen.

He could not move a single step with monsters surging in from every direction. As the crushing weight fell upon him, Xiao Shen shouted.

“The battle isn’t over! Fight until the very end!”

He was right. The battle was not over yet. A Hunter was someone who had to kill monsters until the final moment, until their own breath ran out.

The Hunters who heard Xiao Shen's shout gritted their teeth and swung their weapons.

This will do.

With lightning-fast skill, Xiao Shen buried his dagger in the back of a fleeing ogre's head, then drew a deep breath.

The airplane's massive body was already less than twenty meters[1863] away.

It had slowed considerably, but with everyone trapped in place, avoiding it seemed impossible.

I have no regrets.

If he died fighting for the people as a proud Hunter of Zhonghua[1864], that was enough.

Xiao Shen closed his eyes as screams rained down from every direction. At that moment, he heard:

"Heave-ho."

Krrrunch! Splat!

Drenched in a sticky liquid he assumed was blood, Xiao Shen thought:

…Heave-ho?

Wasn't a person's dying cry usually more like "Aaaah"?

The strange sound was an odd choice for a dying cry, so Xiao Shen slowly raised his eyelids.

At last, he saw it.

The airplane had stopped dead only a few steps away. Two men stood beside it, chatting casually.

"All right, we've arrived. It might explode, so get everyone off quickly."

"…Mr. Jin Taekyung. They're all unconscious."

"Really? How weak."

"…They would have died if not for the Barrier magic."

"Then carry them out, Team Leader Choi. Oh, right. Is that bastard who called us *bangzi*[1865] earlier alive, too?"

"Yes. He's… alive, at least."

"Then keep a close eye on that bastard. I'll keep giving him hell for it when we head back."

"…I'll do my best."

[1863] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

[1864] *Zhonghua* is a Chinese term for China and Chinese civilization, often used to express national identity.

[1865] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans.

Xiao Shen could not make sense of the situation at all.

Who, when, where, what, why, and how—this bizarre sight defied even the five Ws and one H.

How did the airplane suddenly stop, and who are those people? Weren't they Hunters sent by the Central Military Commission?

The two men were even speaking in another language.

Xiao Shen could not understand the words of the clean-cut man who looked like a young master, but he knew what country the language belonged to.

It belonged to Korea, their longtime neighbor.

Wait. If they're Korean…!

Xiao Shen hurriedly wiped the blood from around his eyes. Only then did he recognize one of the men.

A muscular young man who stood a full head taller than everyone else.

The man Xiao Shen had only ever seen on television—his idol—was standing right in front of him.

"C-Could you possibly be Mr. Jin[1866] from Korea?"

"Huh?"

The young man, Jin Taekyung, tilted his head as he looked at Xiao Shen.

"I'm not a teacher."

"Then… Lord Fuck[1867]…"

"…Fuck. What?"

It really is him!

Relief and hope washed over Xiao Shen, making his entire body tremble.

How the hell does a Chinese guy know about Lord Fuck?

Articles about me had caused a brief stir in the foreign media, but I never expected even that nickname to spread this far.

Lord Fuck, making the five oceans and six continents tremble.

If I ever went to the United States, some huge Yankee bros might walk up to me holding beer bottles and act like they knew me.

Hey, you. Lord Fuck?

I'm fine, thank you. Fuck. What kind of deranged bastards came up with a nickname like this?

Anyway…

[1866] The respectful form of address rendered "Mr. Jin" can also mean "teacher," prompting Taekyung's reply.

[1867] A crude online nickname coined after Taekyung accidentally swore during a broadcast.

“What a mess.”

That was my brief assessment as I looked around.

Team Leader Choi, who had strung the unconscious flight attendants together like dried fish, and the Skeleton Warlord, whom I had shoved into my Inventory, both answered me.

“It is a horrifying sight.”

—You wicked human. This commander rather likes this place. It feels familiar and comforting.

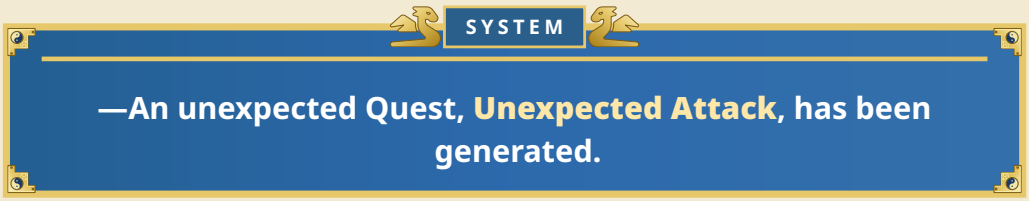
“…”

The fact that a named undead monster—death itself, for all intents and purposes—found the sight pleasing said more than enough.

“We get thrown into actual combat the moment we arrive.”

As if responding to my complaint, a System notification rang.

Ding.



Was this why they said they were paying so much?

I clicked my tongue and spoke.

“Team Leader Choi, protect the civilians first. After that, fight as you see fit. Don’t push yourself too hard.”

“Yes. That was already my intention.”

Team Leader Choi was a smart man. Learning the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique had made him incomparably stronger than before, but he would never show off.

“And you there, young man.”

“Y-Yes, Mr. Jin[1868].”

Mr. Jin? What am I, a schoolteacher?

I looked the young man who had answered so quickly up and down.

His face was young, but he was obviously a Hunter. A powerful one, too—probably around A-rank. Unlike the surrounding Hunters, who all wore identical armor as if they had come off a factory line, he also had a red insignia on his shoulder.

“You look like you hold a pretty significant rank, so take good care of your men. Let’s save even one more person.”

“Y-Yes?”

[1868]The respectful form of address rendered “Mr. Jin” can also mean “teacher,” prompting Taekyung’s reply.

“This is only the beginning.”

As I answered, I thrust out my fist.

Boom!

Streams of Scorching Yang Qi shot toward the monsters standing blankly in place.

Searing heat swept through the area, leaving behind dozens of monster corpses.

“Why are you all staring? Did someone hit the pause button?”

“…!”

—…!

At my single remark, the silence pressing down on the battlefield shattered.

—Graaaar!

“K-Kill them! Stop the monsters!”

Humans against monsters. Monsters against humans.

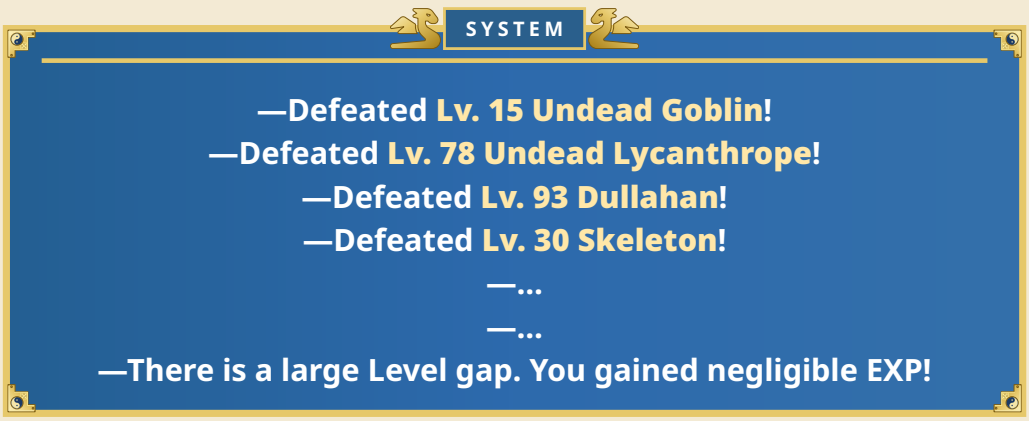
The battle to kill or be killed began anew. I pulled White Flame from where it was embedded deep in the ground and swung it.

Shing!

Forget half water, half fish. Monsters packed every inch of the battlefield.

A crescent of Force extending from the spearhead brushed against a tightly packed cluster of monsters.

Ding.



System notifications announcing monster kills and EXP gains rang out without pause.

Under normal circumstances, I would have let them go in one ear and out the other or simply ignored them.

But this time, they provided an important clue.

“Don’t tell me these things are…”

—Ah, that’s right. Wicked human! What a powerful undead army!

The Skeleton Warlord’s delighted shout was enough to turn my suspicion into certainty.

No wonder something felt strange.

I had already been puzzled by the fact that I could not sense any life force from them.

There were still quite a few living monsters, but more than half were undead. Altogether, they formed a massive army nearly two thousand strong.

“And undead monsters are…”

The Skeleton Warlord shouted, brimming with excitement.

—Beautiful! Magnificent! Heroic!

Thwack!

I cut down five monsters and muttered.

“Want to be erased like that thing just now? Beautifully, magnificently, and heroically?”

—…I misspoke. I apologize, wicked human.

The Skeleton Warlord, who had briefly forgotten its situation, hurriedly added:

—Wait. If that is the case, then they must be under someone’s control!

I thought so, too.

There was only one thing I was not certain about.

“The Lich. Did that bastard come here in person?”

—Hmm. If you mean the Lich from that holographic video you showed me last time, then probably not.

As I listened to the Skeleton Warlord’s answer, I took half a step forward.

Boom!

A massive iron club passed within inches of my shoulder and smashed into the ground. It was an ordinary ogre, still carrying the vitality of a living creature.

—Graaaar!

“Sure. I’ll grill you.”

Boom!

The Flame Divine Palm struck the ogre in the chest, sending dark green blood spurting from its seven apertures.

I passed its collapsing bulk and brought White Flame down at an angle.

Shiiiiing! Slice!

Space itself split apart, and the monsters caught within it were chopped to pieces.

Leaving behind the Chinese Hunter who stared blankly at me while covered in blood and bodily fluids, I clenched my fist.

Whoooom.

Extreme heat surged into my fist, then blasted forward.

Boom!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

A massive pillar of fire swallowed the monsters.

The ones that somehow survived shrieked in agony amid the foul stench of burning flesh.

The destructive power made monsters and Hunters alike forget to fight for a moment.

The Skeleton Warlord spoke in a faltering voice.

—W-Wicked human. You have become even more of a monster.

“It feels strange hearing that from a monster. Anyway, if it wasn’t the Lich, then what kind of bastard is causing all this?”

—How should this commander know? But I can guarantee you one thing.

“Guarantee what?”

—His control over the undead is a notch below mine. Wahaha! Legion! This commander has missed you!

“…”

Should I kill this bastard or let him live?

As I considered the question, an idea suddenly flashed through my mind, and I stopped dead.

“Hey. What did you just say?”

—Wahahaha! Have you finally felt the majesty of this commander, wicked human?

“Talk, or be erased.”

—…I will talk. But what are you asking about?

“That part about controlling the undead.”

—Isn’t it obvious? This commander is a Skeleton Warlord. Compared to them, of course I’m… Huh?

A brief silence followed.

The Skeleton Warlord must have reached the same conclusion I had. I swallowed hard and broached the subject casually.

“Try it. That thing you do.”

—…

“Do it, or be erased.”

The Skeleton Warlord opened its mouth.

—Grow, grow, skeletons, skeletons…

At that moment, the undead monsters locked in fierce battle suddenly froze in place.

…It works.

Chapter 381

Whoooosh.

I couldn’t see it, but I could feel it.

Centered on me—or rather, flowing from the Skeleton Warlord inside the subspace known as my Inventory—a sticky energy spread in every direction.

The change was immediate.

—Kirik?

—Gwoo?

The ferocious monsters abruptly stopped moving.

Orcs, Trolls, goblins, Lycanthropes, every kind of monster I had only ever seen in monster encyclopedias, and even fallen Hunters.

They had only one thing in common: they had already died once and been resurrected as undead.

Gulp.

I swallowed dryly and muttered, “It works.”

—Wow. It really works.

“…?”

—…?

Wait. What did he just say?

My brain froze for a moment. Then I whispered, “What kind of dog-bone bullshit is that? Didn’t you try it because you knew it would work?”

The Skeleton Warlord answered hesitantly.

—The truth is… even this commander did not expect it to work so easily.

“You said your control was much stronger.”

—Ah, that? I just said it in the heat of the moment.

“What?”

—My pride would not allow me to sit around doing nothing…

“…”

Isn’t this guy completely insane?

I was dumbfounded, but regardless, the result was undeniable.

The undead monsters within a radius of several dozen meters[1869] had all stopped moving at once, bringing the fierce battle raging around us to a temporary lull.

“T-The monsters have stopped moving!”

“What in the world is going on?”

“Don’t let your guard down! Some of them are still moving!”

[1869] Several dozen meters is roughly 30–60 m (100–200 ft).

Just as someone shouted, it was still too early to relax.

Only some of the nearby undead monsters had come under the Skeleton Warlord's control. Those farther away, along with the ordinary monsters that were not undead, were unaffected.

—Gwoooooar!

—Chiiik!

"Haaah!"

Clang! Stab!

The uncontrolled monsters were briefly bewildered by the sudden change in their own kind, but they soon began rampaging again, and the battle resumed.

The two sides were hopelessly mismatched in numbers.

But from this moment onward, that was about to change.

I called out in a deliberately hushed voice.

"Go, Warlordmon!"

Warlordmon—no, the Skeleton Warlord—shouted back in outrage.

—Wicked human! Do not call this commander that!

"How about Warlordmon Who's Desperate to Be Erased?"

—…Damn it.

Despite being a skeleton that couldn't even breathe, he let out a deep sigh before chanting a spell.

—Fight, Skeleton Skeleton.

That bastard had definitely started enjoying the whole Skeleton Skeleton thing. It was hardly an impressive incantation, but its effect was undeniable.

—Gwoo?

At the Skeleton Warlord's command, ferocity filled the eyes of the undead monsters that had been standing blankly. Then, in the next moment—

Crunch!

An undead ogre's iron club crushed a Troll's skull.

That was only the beginning.

The undead monsters who had gained a new master charged at their own kind.

—Gwoooooar!

—Ch-Chirik?

Crack! Slice! Stab-stab-stab!

An unexpected ambush from behind.

One flank of the monster army surrounding the Chinese Hunters collapsed helplessly.

—Chiiiiiik!

"W-What the hell!"

“Why are those monsters suddenly…?”

The monsters betrayed by their own kind were not the only ones thrown into confusion.

The Chinese Hunters were just as bewildered by the sudden turn of events.

I shouted to the young Hunter who had been racing across the front lines, swinging his spear.

“Xiao Shen!”

“M-Mr. Jin?”

His eyes widened as he looked at me.

“H-How do you know my name?”

I had just used Qi Sense to check his Level window, but that wasn’t important right now.

“What are you doing? Why aren’t you switching to an all-out offensive?”

“But what is going on here…?”

“Are you really curious about that right now? Do you want to grab an undead monster and make it explain why it’s helping us using the five Ws and one H?”

“N-No, sir!”

“Then what should you be doing?”

Xiao Shen snapped to his senses and thrust his spear into the air.

“Attack formation! Everyone in the Public Security Armed Forces Department, from this moment on, attack everything except the undead monsters!”

“Yes, sir!”

Now that was an excellent decision.

Along with their unified shout, the momentum of the roughly five hundred Hunters who had been driven into a corner changed.

“Kill them!”

“Avenge our fallen comrades!”

Shish-shish-shishik! Slice!

—Awooooo!

A Lycanthrope charged at a Hunter who had just beheaded an Orc.

Its jaws opened, yellow fangs poised to tear out the Hunter’s throat, but a massive fist slammed into its mouth.

Crunch!

—Gwoooooar!

The ogre that had crushed the Lycanthrope’s skull let out a savage roar.

High above the ogre, a Griffon plunged into a steep dive, its razor-sharp claws flashing.

—Kiiiieeeek!

Just as the A-rank monster's mana-infused claws were about to rake across the ogre's eyes—

"Ice Ball!"

"Lightning Bolt!"

The ranged Hunters waiting nearby unleashed their magic. The electrocuted Griffon convulsed in midair.

At that moment, a figure stepped off a Troll's shoulder, launched himself into the air, and swung his weapon at the Griffon.

"Custom-made by J Company, widely considered one of Germany's finest weapon manufacturers—!"

Slice!

A single clean, effortless strike split the Griffon's head in two.

Team Leader Choi landed gracefully and gazed at the transparent blade, not a single drop of blood staining it, with a satisfied smile.

"A longsword I won at auction for 5.2 billion won.[1870] It certainly earns its price."

"…"

It looks stupid, but it's cool.

It's cool, but it looks stupid.

After watching the whole thing, the Skeleton Warlord asked dubiously,

—Wicked human, did you say that man was your superior?

"No, well… Technically, as far as our Guild positions go, he is, but…"

—He seemed reasonably clever for a human, yet I have never encountered anyone so strange. He truly is a fitting superior for you.

"Raise your hand if you're a Skeleton Warlord who wants to be erased for running his mouth."

After a brief silence, the Skeleton Warlord answered by chanting another spell.

—Grow, Skeleton Skeleton!

They say even a dog at a village school can recite poetry after three years. Now he could do it without being told.

Crack. Crack-crack-crack.

The Griffon killed by Team Leader Choi, along with the monsters brought down by the combined attacks of the Hunters and undead, gained new life and rose from their dead bodies.

There were two hundred of them.

The range also seemed wider than during the first attempt. Even distant undead monsters came under the Skeleton Warlord's control and began attacking their former allies.

[1870] 5.2 billion won is about $3.7 million or €3.4 million.

“Wow. You were capable of this?”

—Wow. Was this commander capable of this?

“…”

—…Actually, this commander was not capable of quite this much. But for some reason, an enormous amount of mana is surging through me now that I am here!

“Sure. Great.”

I gave up trying to understand this bizarre named monster.

As long as the result was good, that was all that mattered. Trying to figure it out right now would only give me a headache.

—Give me more. More legions!

I couldn’t see him because he was inside my Inventory, but I was certain his fleshless skull was trembling with excitement.

I sighed and tightened my grip on my spear.

“I was already planning to.”

—Do you have a way?

“I do.”

The method for increasing the number of undead was simple.

“Kill them all.”

—Kahaha! You truly are a wicked and ignorant human!

The bastard was getting cheeky, but this time, I had to agree with at least part of what he said.

With the Skeleton Warlord’s mad laughter echoing through my mind, I stepped forward.

Flamefire Path.

Whoooosh!

A path of flame opened with every step.

Black robes. Staffs hung with dangling skulls.

Their eye sockets were empty, and patches of unrotted flesh still clung to their bodies.

The three beings, each looking as though it had stepped straight out of a nightmare, sent their thoughts to one another.

—There is a problem.

—The undead monsters are slipping out of our control. They are helping the humans and attacking the legion.

—Why?

They were not asking how their control had been broken. The three beings already knew the answer to that question.

—A higher undead. One more powerful than us.

All monsters had a hierarchy, but the undead were ruled by strength more absolutely than any other kind.

If their control had been stolen, it could only be the work of a higher existence.

—But…

—How is that possible?

None of the three beings could answer.

How could an existence more powerful than them be here, seizing control of the undead and helping the humans?

—Could it be that person?

—Absurd. Have you forgotten the command that person gave us when sending us here?

—Kill the humans. Create more undead and a greater legion, then kill more. More humans.

Recalling their command, the three beings fell into confusion.

If that person—the Arch Lich—was not responsible, then who could possibly possess greater control than they did?

—Was there a necromancer among the humans?

—I sensed nothing.

—Humans reject and despise death. That cannot be. Even if one were among them, they would be nothing compared to us.

Unmistakable hostility permeated their thoughts because they, too, had once been necromancers who suffered humanity’s rejection and contempt.

But that had happened in the distant past, in another dimension.

Drifting across the boundless ocean of death, they had met a boatman named the Arch Lich. After gaining new power, they were finally on the verge of becoming the Liches they had longed to be.

But…

—What a shame.

—If only our transformation had been completed. If only there had been more death in this land.

—Then we would not have lost control, either.

The three beings could not hide their regret.

They had been great necromancers while alive, but they had yet to complete their transformation into Liches.

They had been reborn in the bodies of dead mages, but one week was far too short to absorb enough death energy to become full-fledged Liches.

—That is why that person sent all three of us.

—If this mission fails, that person will be disappointed.

—That person might even take back the power they gave us.

That was what the three beings feared most.

If they wanted to earn the Arch Lich's favor, they had to overcome this crisis somehow.

Even if it meant expending a tremendous amount of power.

—There is no other choice.

—Are you suggesting we combine our strength?

—Yes. If the three of us combine our strength, even an unidentified higher undead will no longer be able to steal control from us.

—Hmm. Fine.

—Do you agree?

—I agree.

The three beings, who had been competing for the Arch Lich's favor, finally reached an agreement.

Without hesitation, they began chanting necromantic spells.

—Valencia. Madrid.

—Bayern. Munich.

—Stoke. City.

The energy of death flowing from the three beings spread through the air.

The green grass turned black, and the soldiers of the People's Liberation Army within range clutched their throats and collapsed.

"Ghk!"

"Guhhh!"

Whoooosh.

As the humans breathed their last, death energy flowed from their bodies and seeped into every part of the monsters.

—Kyaaaaaaah!

—Gwoooooar!

The air trembled with the powerful mana carried in their savage cries. Their strength was beyond comparison with that of ordinary monsters.

Only after sensing their strengthened control and the greater power of the monsters under their command did the three beings stop chanting.

—Kikikikik.

—Success.

—We consumed an enormous amount of power… but this is more than enough.

Just as the three beings smiled in satisfaction at their newly empowered legion—

Boom!

Far away, a monster’s limbs flew through the air amid a thunderous explosion.

The three beings watched the flames rise and exchanged thoughts.

—There appears to be a flame mage. Not bad.

—He is still only human. Deploy the Skeleton Mages in force.

—Good idea.

A short while later, flames erupted again, and the three beings looked at one another.

—What was that just now?

—Our control was severed. It was not stolen.

—He erased them? Impressive.

—But is he truly a mage? His movements seem far too fast…

—Let us deploy the ogre unit.

—I’ll see your ogres and raise you Dullahans.

—Dullahans, too? Then who will protect us?

—He is right. Dullahans would be excessive. The strengthened ogres will be enough.

—That is true.

Three minutes later, a grim atmosphere hung over the three beings’ skulls.

—It was severed.

—Again?

—I told you we should send the Dullahans.

—What is that thing? It does not seem to be a mage.

—J-Just send the Dullahans first!

—Th-Then we shall do so.

The three beings watched as the more than twenty Dullahans assigned as their escort force rushed away. Then they quietly began searching for another point of agreement.

—Hmm. It is unlikely that such a thing will happen, but just in case…

—I had a similar thought.

—Should we create a Death Knight?

—We have already consumed too much power. A Death Knight, too? We do not have suitable materials, and it would take a long time.

—Given the urgency, we can simply choose the most useful one available. If the three of us combine our strength, it will be possible.

—Th-Then should we try?

But the three beings’ plan to create a Death Knight was shattered less than ten minutes later.

Whoosh! Boom!

Even with bodies reduced to little more than bone, they could feel the searing heat.

“Fucking bastards. There’s a shitload of them.”

Crunch!

The three beings watched a figure tear through the monster army with a spear engulfed in hellfire and hurriedly began chanting spells.

Their once slow, dragging voices became as fast as rap.

—Omnehasoyu!

—Yenwigajike!

But before they could complete their spells, the young human—impossible to identify as either a flame mage or a warrior—had already arrived right in front of them.

“Oh, nice to meet you.”

—O-Omnehasoyu!

—Y-Yes, Yenwigajike!

The young man, Jin Taekyung, cocked his head.

“Hello. *Entertainment Weekly*? Are you idiots?”[1871]

[1871] The garbled incantations sound like *annyeonghaseyo, Yeonye-ga Junggye* (“Hello, *Entertainment Weekly*”), the title of a long-running Korean entertainment-news program.

Chapter 382

Strike the head, and the body falls.

Once I captured the three who appeared to be the leaders, the undead under their control stopped moving like wind-up dolls. Deprived of its commanders, the monster army scattered. Some were killed, while others fled.

“Arch Lich?”

At my question, the three kneeling figures nodded.

I wasn’t sure whether things that were already dead and reduced to bones could still be called “guys,” but whatever.

I stroked each of the three skulls in turn and continued.

“When someone talks to you, you’re supposed to answer. Are you putting on airs just because you’re dead?”

They answered before I had even finished speaking.

—Yes. Yes. It is an Arch Lich.

—What you heard was correct, honored human.

—Indeed.

“Hmm. An Arch Lich. That’s a monster I’ve never heard of before… But which one of you answered informally at the end?”

—That one!

—How dare he speak so casually to the great human!

Whip! Whip!

Two bony fingers pointed at the third.

His companions’ lightning-fast betrayal left the accused skull trembling.

—No! This is a despicable false accusation!

“…Doesn’t sound like a false accusation to me.”

If he was going to lie, he could at least change the way he talked.

After glancing around, I pulled *that* out of my Inventory.

“Bones. Snack time.”

It was a skull with a strange black sheen, flames flickering in its empty eye sockets.

—…Bones? If you insist on giving me a nickname, call me Warlordmon like before.

“Why? You’re a skeleton, so Bones. It fits perfectly.”

—How dare you insult this commander!

“Fine. Forget it, then.”

Just as I was about to put it back in my Inventory, the Skeleton Warlord shouted indignantly.

—Thank you for the meal!

“What an honest little guy.”

Honest children deserved rewards. Liars deserved punishment.

“All right. Have a taste.”

—Thank you, slightly less wicked human. But how much may I eat…?

“Just a little, like before.”

—Hmm. I would like more, but very well.

Even snacks were too much if you gave them out too often. After expressing its slight disappointment, the Skeleton Warlord opened its jaws wide toward the trembling figure.

—Come here.

—E-Eek! No!

—Yes!

The change began with the Skeleton Warlord’s decisive shout.

Whoooosh!

That was still amazing, even after seeing it once before.

Black mist poured from the kneeling figure’s body and streamed into the Skeleton Warlord as though being sucked up by a vacuum cleaner.

—Gaaaaah!

And that wasn’t the only change.

As more of the black mist—the substance the Skeleton Warlord called death energy—flowed out, the figure’s complexion grew steadily paler.

Or rather, its bones did.

Meanwhile, the Skeleton Warlord’s black sheen grew deeper and richer.

—S-Stop!

—Heh heh heh. What delicious death energy.

—Nooo!

—This commander shall take it all. Deeeath energy!

Crack!

—Hrk!

“Cut the ‘deeeath energy’ crap. Where did you even learn something like that?”

—…Are you really in a position to say that?

“Anyway, stop eating.”

—Why?!

“You’ll get fat.”

The Skeleton Warlord was momentarily lost for words. I tucked it inside my clothes and looked at its victim.

When I had first seen the creature, its bones had been dark and grimy. Now, half of its skeleton had turned white. Perhaps because so much of its death energy had been drained, the green flames in its eye sockets flickered unsteadily.

—Hrk… H-Hrk…

At the sight of their weakened companion, sucked dry to the bone, the other two anxiously clacked their teeth.

—Ask anything of us, great ruler of flame.

—Please, I beg of you. Accept the loyalty of this insignificant being, Orpheus von Maximus Valencia Bayern.

"…You're undead, not a bidet."

They must have been desperate not to lose their power. Not that I minded them being so cooperative.

"All right. If there's anything you haven't told me yet, scrape the bottom of the barrel and spill every last bit of it. If you feed me so much as one lie…"

—We will tell you everything!

—Please, I beg of you! Grant this false and insignificant being permission to speak the truth!

—I-I'll talk.

Apparently unwilling to become bone broth, all three skeletons threw themselves enthusiastically into the interrogation.

They told me everything that had happened, from the Arch Lich's first appearance a week ago to the events of today. Once they had finished, I frowned for effect.

"You're sure?"

—Yes, great human!

—I swear upon the River of Death!

—N-Not a single word was false.

As all three skulls nodded furiously, the Skeleton Warlord cut in.

—They speak the truth.

"Did they pay you off? How can you guarantee that?"

—They swore upon the River of Death. For beings such as us, that is an absolute vow. It can never be broken.

"Hmm."

The guy was usually as frivolous as dust in the wind. Hearing it speak with such gravity made me think it probably wasn't lying.

Besides, the three of them had no reason to scheme in a situation like this.

"All right. I believe you."

—Thank you! Thank you so much!

—Hrk, hrk! I shall serve you with all my heart, my king!

—I-I mean, I too shall swear loyalty to you, honored human. I swear upon the River of Death that I will never again commit such an act—

Crunch!

The last skeleton faltered before it could finish.

His trembling green eye light shifted back and forth between the fist embedded in his chest and me.

—W-Why?

“What do you mean, why?”

—I-I, loyalty, swear, River of Death…

“Too late.”

A voice so cold it hardly sounded like mine slipped between my lips.

“It’s too late to undo what you’ve done.”

Countless people had died here today.

Even regular troops armed with firearms and Hunters had been unable to stop them, so there was no telling how many civilians the monster army had killed over the past week.

“I don’t need your loyalty. Especially not from bastards like you.”

The moment I released the Scorching Yang Qi I had drawn up from my dantian—

Whoosh!

Extreme Yang energy erupted from the fist lodged between its shattered ribs. Blue-white Force radiating unimaginable heat coiled around its entire body.

Rooooar!

I watched the green flames in its eye sockets flicker like candles in the wind, then go out.

I also saw the other two figures spring to their feet and begin chanting spells.

—Jazuchawa Umbado…!

—Vargan Mahra…!

Whoooom.

A wind of magical power swirled around them. Just as their sinister spell was about to be completed, I casually said,

“Devour them. Both of them.”

As though it had been waiting for those very words, the Skeleton Warlord sprang from between the folds of my clothes and opened its jaws wide.

—Gladly.

—Varsaba… Eek!

—N-No!

The monsters screamed in a final, desperate bid to live—or rather, to continue existing as undead.

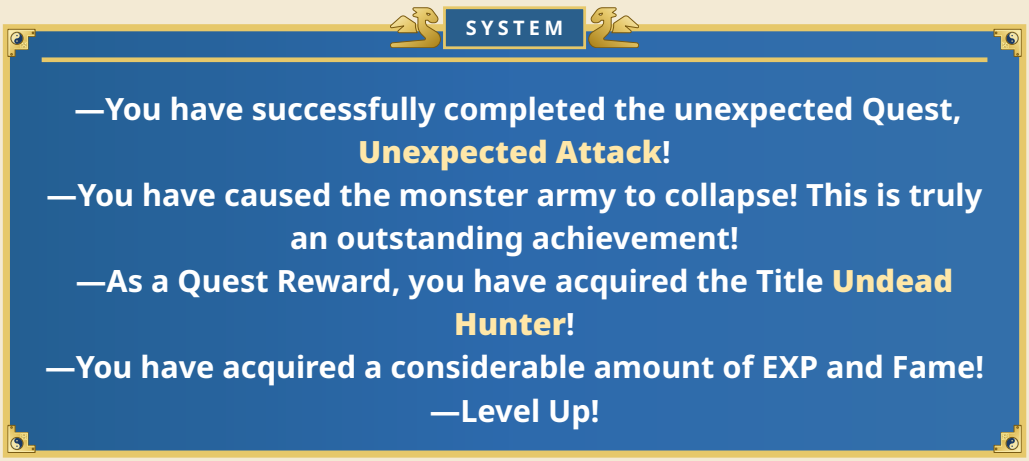
Their wishes meant nothing. The Skeleton Warlord’s pull was stronger and faster than ever.

Whoooosh! Gulp!

The Skeleton Warlord swallowed an enormous quantity of death energy in a single bite, and its skull shuddered.

A moment later, the two skeletons, completely drained of energy, collapsed into piles of bone.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Only once?

In the past, I would have leveled up several times without difficulty. But now that I had reached Level 120, it seemed the amount of EXP I needed had increased.

Not that I did it for the EXP.

I had merely done what needed to be done, but I couldn't help feeling a little disappointed.

After all, the stronger I became, the more useful I would be in the battles ahead.

The same goes for that guy.

I looked at the Skeleton Warlord while thinking to myself.

Thanks to the enormous amount of death energy it had absorbed, the power emanating from it was on a completely different level from when we had first met.

—Hmm. Hoooo…

Black mist billowed through the holes in its skull where its nose, ears, and eyes should have been.

Its violet eye flames burned like torches, and its smooth surface gleamed with a deep black luster. A moment later, its crazed laughter thundered through my head.

—Kaha! Kahahahaha!

"Turn down the volume. You're loud."

—Wicked human. This time, this commander offers you his profound gratitude.

"You should. Who do you think fed you?"

—Fed me?! Are you implying that this body is some sort of pet?!

"Close enough. Isn't it?"

—Don't be absurd!

“Oh? Bones, come here.”

I held out my hand. The skull immediately sprang into the air and landed in my palm.

As a reward, I gently scratched it between the eyes.

“Good boy, Bones. Aren’t you adorable?”

—…!

The skull trembled.

—H-How could this happen?! How could this commander be treated like this by a mere human?!

“You say no with your mouth, but your body is honest.”

—I am the master of the Black Forest and the commander of the great undead army. Do not humiliate this body!

“A commander who’s nothing but a head?”

—What?! This paltry body can be restored whenever I wish, so long as I expend enough death energy!

“Really? Then why haven’t you restored it yet?”

—…Because even if I did, some lunatic human would just smash it again.

“Oh, correct.”

The toothless Skeleton Warlord ground its jawbones together, its eye flames narrowing.

—Why, wicked human?

“Why what?”

—There must be some ulterior motive behind feeding me—no, behind granting me such immense power. You clearly have some dark scheme in mind. Tell me the truth!

I thought for a moment before answering.

“Hmm. Because you’re a fucking scrub.”

—What?

“You can’t beat me anyway. If I’m going to keep a scrub around, it might as well be a stronger, more useful one. That’ll make you easier to put to work. Don’t you agree?”

—…!

“All right. Get back inside. People are coming.”

I put the Skeleton Warlord, frozen in shock, back into my Inventory and stood.

The airport duty-free corridor would normally have been crowded with employees and passengers. Now it was empty and dark, and three people were walking toward me.

Two of them were familiar.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

"Mr. Jin."

They were Team Leader Choi, who looked relatively unscathed, and Xiao Shen, an A-rank Hunter from China's Public Security Armed Forces Department.

A fair amount of time had passed since the battle ended, but Xiao Shen was still covered in blood and dust, his face haggard with exhaustion.

"There you are."

I exchanged a look of greeting with Team Leader Choi before making an excuse.

"Yes. I had something to take care of."

"Please speak casually with me. Fuc—no, Mr. Jin, you are the hero who saved me, my comrades, and even the people of Zhonghua[1872]."

"…"

Was that my imagination, or had he almost called me Lord Fuck just now?

Whether he knew what I was thinking or not, Xiao Shen continued in an extremely respectful tone.

"Fortunately, with the help of the two gentlemen from the Peace Guild, we were able to defeat the monsters. I would like to take this opportunity to thank you once again."

"Oh, sure. It was nothing. I only did what anyone should have."

I waved my hands modestly and stole a glance at Team Leader Choi.

I had been worried the *Integrated Language Pack* might malfunction and make him notice something strange. But since I was currently speaking with Xiao Shen, it seemed Team Leader Choi was hearing my words in Chinese as well.

"But who is the gentleman beside you…?"

He was the only unfamiliar face among the three.

The gray-haired, middle-aged man who had been silently listening to our conversation extended his hand.

"I am Wei Fenghu, Minister of National Defense under the Central Military Commission. It is a pleasure to meet you, Mr. Jin."

"Minister of National Defense…"

"My rank is general."

"Ah."

I understood that he was a big deal, but I had no idea what that rank actually meant.

Perhaps he had read my thoughts, because Team Leader Choi whispered from beside me in a voice barely louder than an ant.

"Four-star. Four-star."

"Ah. Ahhh! You're a general! It's a pleasure to meet you!"

[1872] *Zhonghua* is a patriotic Chinese name for China.

I had been a four-star once, too. That game I played as a kid had been a lot of fun. The sequel had bombed spectacularly, though.

Wei Fenghu clasped my hand, a faint smile touching his lips.

“You are full of youthful vigor. I have many things I would like to ask you, but shall we talk while we walk?”

“Sure.”

I started after Wei Fenghu, then paused.

“Where are we going?”

“To the operations headquarters. I have a jet waiting.”

“What? Headquarters? A jet?”

“That is correct. Everyone is waiting for you there, Mr. Jin.”

Everyone? Who?

Chapter 383

The jet Wei Fenghu had prepared looked nothing like what I had imagined.

It's spacious. And fancy.

Through the partly open cabin door, I could see a luxurious table and one of those so-called chairman's chairs.

Team Leader Choi, who was standing beside me, informed us that the business jet we were looking at cost nearly one hundred billion won[1873] per plane, then added,

"I never expected to see an aircraft reserved for state guests here."

"That is only natural. The two of you are state guests of our country."

"Ah."

"Thanks to you, we were able to save countless soldiers and Hunters. None of us—not even me—will ever forget the help you gave us today."

"…Ah, yes."

I would have preferred it if they dealt with the fine dust and historical distortions first.

Still, I boarded the jet, privately hoping China was a more conscientious country than I gave it credit for.

The waiting pilot saluted us—or, more precisely, Wei Fenghu—with crisp, disciplined movements.

"You have arrived, Comrade Minister of National Defense."

"Are we ready?"

"This aircraft and all its escorts are ready. We await your order."

I wondered what he meant by "escorts," but then I looked through the window and saw five sleek fighter jets on the runway, their lights blinking as though signaling us.

What the hell are those?

I'd only ever seen things like that in war movies. Were we flying off to fight a battle or something?

Wei Fenghu saw my eyes widen and explained.

"The details have not yet been made public…but as you know, Sichuan Province is currently in a state of war. Magical interference has disrupted communications, and attacks by flying monsters are frequent. An escort is essential for our safety."

"Is that really true?"

The situation was more serious than I'd thought.

[1873] Nearly one hundred billion won is about $71 million and €65 million.

The Wyvern had only attacked us in passing while raiding Chengdu International Airport. But if the same thing was happening throughout Sichuan Province, that changed everything.

"I wish I were lying."

Perhaps merely thinking about the current situation exhausted him. Wei Fenghu, who seemed to have aged considerably in a short time, leaned back into the soft seat.

"It seems we must part ways here. We will meet again soon, Senior Colonel Xiao Shen."

Unlike us, Xiao Shen had not boarded the aircraft. He stood rigidly at attention and saluted.

"Yes, Comrade Minister of National Defense. I will complete my mission as quickly as possible and rejoin you. And, gentlemen…"

"Good. I expect great things from you."

Perhaps because he had achieved such impressive accomplishments, a pleased smile passed across Wei Fenghu's lips as he looked at the promising young Hunter.

Team Leader Choi gave him a polite bow. I waved.

"See you next time. You fought really well today."

It was only one sentence.

But the moment Xiao Shen heard my words, his eyes grew as wide as serving trays. His body trembled as though he had been electrocuted, and then he shouted at the top of his lungs.

"Th-Thank you! I will devote myself to every task with the utmost loyalty,[1874] so that I never disappoint you, Mr. Jin!"

"…You don't need to go that far."

"May your august self remain safe! Loooyalty!"

"'August self'? What are you—"

Whack!

"Urk!"

"…"

That looked like a textbook example of poor judgment.

He'd saluted so hard that the edge of his hand struck him in the eyebrow.

As I stared dumbfounded at Xiao Shen clenching his teeth against the pain, the cabin door closed and our business jet began to take off.

"That guy is, well… How should I put it? He's quite a character."

Wei Fenghu gave a quiet laugh at my awkward observation.

"Can you blame him? His idol praised him."

[1874] A Korean idiom for offering one's utmost loyal service, literally "the labor of a dog or horse."

"Excuse me?"

"Many young Hunters in our country admire you, Mr. Jin. He is no exception."

What the hell? Was I a Korean Wave star?

Come to think of it, for a four-star general with enough power to make birds fall from the sky, Wei Fenghu seemed unusually attentive to his subordinates.

Or maybe Xiao Shen was simply that promising.

Ah, but…

—Team Leader. How important is the Minister of National Defense under the Central Military Commission, exactly? I'm not very familiar with the structure over here.

Team Leader Choi flinched at my Sound Transmission, then replied through Message Magic.

—If you compare it to our country, he is the Minister of National Defense. Of course, this is China, and Wei Fenghu is the current Chairman's right-hand man, so his power is considerably greater.

—Ah.

So he's a lot like me. I'm the Minister of gukbap.[1875]

One special serving of sundae-guk[1876] was enough to handle three bowls of rice.

Of course, Wei Fenghu could probably erase three cities with a single pointed finger.

And now, that powerful figure of the People's Republic of China was leaning his upper body toward us and asking,

"It seems we have much to discuss during the flight. Would you not agree?"

Team Leader Choi and I nodded solemnly and opened our mouths.

"Of course. First, I would like to ask what exactly is happening in Sichuan—"

"But do you happen to have any boiled eggs and soda? I'm hungry after fighting so hard."

"…"

"…"

Apparently, they didn't.

"We do."

"…?"

"…?"

They actually did.

[1875] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup; Taekyung is riffing on the similar sound of *gukbangbu*, the Ministry of National Defense.

[1876] *Sundae-guk* is a Korean soup made with *sundae*, a type of blood sausage.

The People’s Republic of China.

As its formal name suggested, the people of this vast and imposing nation still adhered to socialism as their national ideology.

About twenty years ago, the Chairman at the time—who had cemented the foundations of his dictatorship by securing lifelong rule—died during the Great Cataclysm. Power then passed to a far more moderate administration, but the substance of the system remained unchanged.

—What was the dead Chairman’s name again? Pingping? Paengpaeng?

Team Leader Choi, who had been chiming in as Wei Fenghu spoke, silently moved his lips. His poker face was astonishing.

—Just so you know, saying something like that here could get you into serious trouble.

—That’s why I’m using Sound Transmission—no, Message Magic.

—I’m telling you to be careful. Some exceptional mages of A rank or higher can eavesdrop on Message Magic.

—Anyway, what was his name? Pingping or Paengpaeng? If you don’t tell me, I won’t be able to sleep tonight.

—…Pingping.

You were going to answer me in the end anyway.

Now that I was finally satisfied, I listened closely to Wei Fenghu’s words.

“No one could have predicted it.”

Sichuan Province was enormous, both in area and in population, with tens of millions of residents.

And it had all begun in Gaoping District, part of Nanchong City—one of the roughly twenty administrative divisions in Sichuan Province.

“As you know, our country has more than ten times as many Gates as other nations. That made us one of the countries hit hardest during the Great Cataclysm, and we have managed them with corresponding rigor ever since.”

But human power could not control even natural disasters, and the Monster Wave was a calamity far worse than any natural disaster.

“We received word that the mana levels in Gaoping District had suddenly spiked exactly thirteen minutes after the first signs appeared. And by the time Lei Fei, head of the Public Security Armed Forces Department stationed in Sichuan Province, arrived at the scene with the Hunters under his command…everything was already too late.”

“Lei Fei?”

The name was unfamiliar. Yet for some reason, a memory surfaced.

That video Team Leader Choi showed me at the Guild House before we left.

I still remembered it vividly. A city plunged into utter chaos beneath the glow of a hologram, and one man at the head of the Hunters, cutting his way through the monsters.

His weapon had shone with a dazzling aura.

“I think I’ve seen him before. Was he the man in the video you sent us…?”

“That is correct.”

Wei Fenghu hesitated, then continued with a faint sigh.

“He was one of our country’s S-rank Hunters. Of course, neither of you would have known about him.”

We wouldn’t have known?

There were only twenty S-rank Hunters in the entire world. Each of them was an absolute powerhouse.

The fame and status they enjoyed far surpassed even those of a Supreme Peak master in Murim.

The internet, news, and social media were their stages, while microphones and cameras followed them like shadows.

The common people of Murim regarded martial artists with equal parts wariness and curiosity, but modern people saw Hunters as objects of pure admiration. They were global celebrities.

And we’re supposed to have never heard of an S-rank Hunter?

Wei Fenghu had phrased it indirectly, but his meaning was clear.

Team Leader Choi’s gaze met mine in midair. At that moment, we were thinking the same thing.

An undisclosed S-rank Hunter.

No—to be precise, an S-rank Hunter deliberately concealed by the Chinese government.

I’d only ever heard rumors about this. So they were true?

An S-rank Hunter was practically the face of a nation.

But unlike the weak, who struggled desperately to avoid being underestimated, the strong concealed their claws.

China was already known to possess two S-rank Hunters. Clearly, it had no intention of revealing the full extent of its strength.

Perhaps the same was true of the world’s other major powers.

Good grief. Even after surviving the Great Cataclysm, they’re still playing this kind of game of nerves.

It was pathetic, but at the same time, I thought I could understand it. Diplomacy. Politics. I felt as though I had caught a glimpse of the truths of a world I had never known, and the feeling was strange.

Team Leader Choi, however, was sharper than I was.

"You said he 'was' one of your country's S-rank Hunters. That sounded like the past tense."

Wei Fenghu answered with a devastated expression.

"…Lei Fei disappeared a week ago, when the first Monster Wave began. The Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department under his command vanished with him."

"Are you certain he is only missing? Could he perhaps…"

"We could not confirm his death. After that video was recorded, the monster known as the Lich—no, the Arch Lich—blocked all communications and surveillance with mana."

Team Leader Choi and I both groaned.

At our reaction, Wei Fenghu asked in a hoarse voice,

"Do you also believe Lei Fei is dead?"

"Hmm."

"Uh…"

Missing for a week in the middle of that hellscape? The outcome was practically a foregone conclusion.

Team Leader Choi shot me a look, so I cautiously began,

"Well, you never know what might happen to someone, but…"

"The other experts said there was a one-hundred-percent chance he was dead. Useless windbags, every last one of them."

Come on. They sound like real experts to me.

Anyone who confidently claimed Lei Fei was still alive after seeing that situation deserved to be fired on the spot. That was simply the truth.

"But I disagree. Lei Fei—my boy—is certainly alive."

"I hope so too, but realistically speaking…"

"He is my only nephew. My sister was sickly from childhood and died in childbirth. I took in her baby before he was even weaned and raised him as my own son."

"Excuse me?"

His nephew? He raised him like a son? What the hell was this?

As I sat frozen like a statue, Wei Fenghu asked me with damp eyes,

"What were you about to say? After 'realistically speaking.'"

Fuck. This is the worst crisis I've ever faced.

The words lodged in my throat. I barely managed to force them out.

"I was going to say that, realistically speaking, there's still a chance he might be alive."

"Is that so? Is that really true?"

"Ah, yes. But the odds are extremely slim—"

"Thank you, Mr. Jin!"

"No, General. Commander. Supreme Leader. Please hold on and let me finish…"

He seized my hand.

Too late. Wei Fenghu was no longer listening. Instead, he clasped my hand between both of his, his eyes brimming with tears.

"May I ask you one favor?"

I really wish you wouldn't.

Contrary to my desperate hopes, a few seconds later, the one sentence I had expected pierced my heart.

"If you happen to meet that boy someday, could you bring him back to me?"

"…"

"I beg you."

Over Wei Fenghu's shoulder, I saw Team Leader Choi shaking his head.

What if I'd just been firm from the start? I regretted it, but it was too late.

In the end, there was only one answer I could give.

"I will. But…"

"Mr. Jin."

"Yes?"

"You need not say it. I am already prepared for what may happen."

"…!"

Wei Fenghu wiped his eyes with his sleeve. In an instant, he was no longer a middle-aged man worried about his family. He had become the Minister of National Defense under the Central Military Commission once more.

"This is enough. No one else was willing to step forward, but you have given me your word, Mr. Jin. I can rest easier now."

"I can't promise anything."

"I did not need someone's boastful guarantee. What I needed was a thread of hope."

Just as Wei Fenghu murmured those words, the aircraft began to descend, accompanied by a sudden sensation of floating.

Outside the window, beneath a blanket of deep darkness, I could see rugged mountain ridges, lights moving without pause, and military vehicles.

"It seems we have arrived."

I stared out at the landscape as though possessed, then asked,

"Where are we?"

"A temporary operations headquarters."

"No. That's not what I meant."

"Hmm?"

“For some reason, that mountain feels strangely familiar.”

“That cannot be. As far as I know, you have never visited our country… Ah, perhaps you saw it in a photograph?”

“A photograph?”

“It is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. That would certainly be possible.”

With a faint smile, Wei Fenghu continued,

“Temporary operations headquarters. Welcome to Mount Qingcheng.”

Chapter 384

Mount Qingcheng.

A sacred Taoist site steeped in ages past.

Anyone who stood before its stern, overwhelming peaks would be struck speechless.

But I was amazed for an entirely different reason.

It's definitely different…but it looks so similar.

Mount Qingcheng in Murim. Mount Qingcheng in the modern twenty-first century.

The two worlds I had experienced resembled each other in many ways—their terrain, languages, people's features, and even their ways of life.

At one point, I had even wondered whether Murim might be the distant past of the modern world.

But it wasn't.

The butterfly effect? There was no way something I had only ever seen in movies had actually happened.

The two worlds were certainly similar, but there were subtle differences between them, and their histories were different as well.

The world of Murim was also smaller than the modern one, with no five oceans or six continents.

People with colored eyes lived in far-off foreign lands, but that was all. The center of that world was a continent ruled by a vast Great Nation.

Perhaps the Zhonghua[1877] the Chinese never tired of going on about was Murim itself.

But why did even this have to be similar?

I had barely returned from the Three-Gate Bloodbath, which had mercilessly drenched Sichuan Province in blood, only to find myself at Mount Qingcheng in modern-day Sichuan.

I couldn't tell whether it was a simple coincidence or some terrible twist of fate.

I only hoped the similarities didn't extend that far…

"Mr. Jin?"

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Ah."

I raised my head like someone waking from sleep.

Wei Fenghu and Team Leader Choi had already gotten off the business jet and were looking at me strangely.

"Sorry. I got distracted by the scenery for a moment."

[1877] *Zhonghua* is a Chinese term for China that also invokes the idea of Chinese civilization.

"It is so dark, yet you can still appreciate the magnificent scenery of Mount Qingcheng. You truly possess extraordinary mana, Mr. Jin."

That wasn't exactly wrong, but now that I had reached the Supreme Peak realm, I could see through most darkness with my eyesight alone, without relying on internal energy.

When I nodded with a complicated expression, Wei Fenghu gazed at me in admiration.

"Now I understand why Korea has kept you hidden so carefully, Mr. Jin. You are indeed worthy of being called an S-rank Hunter—the face of your nation."

"Excuse me? I'm still officially A-rank."

"There is no need to hide it. Our country has already ascertained the situation to some extent."

Before I could respond, Wei Fenghu continued without pause.

"To become an S-rank Hunter, one must attain enlightenment through relentless mental discipline and arduous training. Our country also endured countless trials and errors to cultivate the Hunters we have today…but for someone as young as you to have reached such a realm, the Korean government must have given you its full support."

"…?"

"…?"

"Of course, Mr. Choi beside you is also an excellent Hunter. With the two of you here together, I feel greatly reassured."

What kind of hearty gukbap nonsense was that?[1878]

Team Leader Choi and I exchanged a brief glance and reached a silent agreement.

Keep your mouth shut.

Let's just go.

Apparently, this misunderstanding had arisen because I had reached my current level in such an absurdly unrealistic way. But if they had already decided to slap that label on me, there was no reason for us to peel it off for them.

Besides, convincing Wei Fenghu otherwise right here would be a pain.

"Hmm. I think there's been a slight misunderstanding, but I'll explain everything bit by bit when the time comes."

"What is there to misunderstand? We both know how things stand."

"…"

"…"

"Even the Chairman already knows about the matter. When you meet him, do not bother denying it. Just accept it as it is."

[1878] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup and is commonly considered a hearty, filling meal. Taekyung twists Wei Fenghu's confident reassurance into a joke about "hearty" gukbap.

Aware of what?

I let out a quiet laugh.

Speaking of the Chairman…

He was like a king, holding more than a billion people and the economy and military of the People's Republic of China in the palm of his hand.

Even now that I had reached the Supreme Peak realm, he felt both close and impossibly distant to someone like me, whose modern-day common sense remained rooted to the bone.

I wonder if I'll get to see him once this is all over.

Well, what did it matter? That was a question for much later.

Even without my raid pay, my weekly salary was a staggering ten billion won.[1879] As far as I was concerned, he was simply a generous employer.

I got to save people and make money. Two birds with one stone.

"I'll do that. If I meet him."

"Good. Then let us go meet him."

"Excuse me?"

"Did I not tell you? He is waiting in the underground bunker right now."

What the hell is going on?

I stared blankly at Wei Fenghu's retreating back, then hurried over to Team Leader Choi and whispered,

"D-Did you hear that?"

"Yes, I did. But I find it rather surprising as well. For the Chairman of China to leave the safety of Beijing and come all the way here… It seems his public reputation is at least partly deserved."

"To hell with his reputation. China's Jongseok—Jongseok!"

"Not Jongseok, General Secretary! The Chairman!"

"Hmm? What did you just say?"

"Nothing, Minister."

When Wei Fenghu suddenly glanced back, Team Leader Choi politely covered for us. Then he turned to me with the most grave and earnest expression I had ever seen on his face.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung. You must not make that kind of verbal mistake in front of the Chairman. Understood? Especially not Jongseok. Don't even mention it. It sounds like the name of some high school classmate."

"Huh? How did you know?"

"…"

I think Team Leader Choi just muttered fuck.

[1879] Ten billion Korean won is about $7.1 million or €6.5 million.

Must be my imagination.

I took a deep breath and repeated the words to myself.

Not Jongseok. General Secretary. The Chairman of China.

Unlike Team Leader Choi, who had been born into the highest tier of nobility, I was an ordinary citizen to my core.

Whatever feelings I normally had toward China, my heart pounded at the thought of meeting the leader of one of the ten most powerful nations in the world.

Just don't make a mistake. Especially not Jongseok.

Ten minutes later, deep inside an underground bunker, I shook hands with the leader of the People's Republic of China under the gazes of the important figures gathered there.

"Pleased to meet you, Mr. Jin. This old man is Xiao Yang, Chairman of the People's Republic of China."

Good. Not even a hint of Jongseok.

Having cleared that hurdle, I opened my mouth at ease.

"Welcome."

"…?"

"…?"

Ah, fuck.

Chairman of the Chinese Communist Party's Central Military Commission. General Secretary. And the head of state who stood at the apex of more than a billion people.

Xiao Yang.

His voice directed at the people was gentle, while strength filled his eyes.

"As you all know, I am unfortunately neither a military expert nor an outstanding general. I am merely a schemer who entered politics at an early age and managed to fulfill one small ambition only after reaching the age of seventy."

It was astonishing to hear the leader of the country with the fourth-largest territory and largest population on Earth call himself a schemer.

So this is what Team Leader Choi meant by the public perception of him?

I felt as if I had a rough idea of what kind of person he was.

Perhaps it was merely a mask he wore in front of others. Perhaps it was hypocrisy.

But at least from the old man speaking before all of us now, including me—Xiao Yang, the Chairman of China—I sensed a kind of qi utterly unlike either of those things.

"Please do your utmost. Save as many of our people as you can, and bring this terrible disaster to an end as quickly as possible. If you do, I will express gratitude

worthy of what you and your countries have done, and I will long remember the aid you have given us.”

The truth was, I knew nothing about the life that old man had lived or the policies he had pursued.

But I wanted to give him considerable credit for reaching out to countries around the world to save his own people.

“That is all this old man has to say. Please do not concern yourselves with complicated matters such as politics. I earnestly ask that you find the best way to resolve this crisis with the fewest possible sacrifices.”

The old statesman who had devoted his entire life to politics turned toward one man.

“Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu. My old friend.”

“Yes, respected Chairman Comrade.”

“Do you want full authority over the Central Military Commission?”

Wei Fenghu hesitated for a moment, then nodded gravely.

“I do.”

“You could use that power well. But I must refuse.”

“…Chairman Comrade?”

“Bring me the orders once this meeting is over. I will assume full authority—and full responsibility—for everything that follows.”

For a moment, I wondered why China’s Jongseok was acting like that.

Then I understood. He was declaring that he would shoulder everything himself.

Watching from beside me, Team Leader Choi murmured,

“He’s a good leader.”

I quietly shook my head.

“No. To me, you’re the best, Team Leader Choi.”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung…”

“So please raise my Guild settlement percentage.”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung…”

The same words, yet a completely different feeling.

Team Leader Choi gave me a look that said, *Of course you’d say that, you bastard,* and shook his head. Just then, the secretary announced,

“The Chairman is departing.”

At the secretary’s announcement, everyone rose from their seats. It was the least courtesy owed to a head of state.

“I wish you all good fortune in battle.”

The Chairman addressed every person present, meeting each one’s eyes in turn. Naturally, I was no exception.

Unfortunately, I was the very last.

“Mr. Jin.”

“…Yes.”

A faint smile touched the Chairman’s lips as he looked at me.

“I have very high expectations of you, Mr. Jin. Although this is a contract through which we each receive what we need, I hope you will prioritize human life under all circumstances.”

Was it my imagination, or was his farewell much longer than the ones he had given everyone else?

Feeling the others’ eyes on me, I nodded.

“Understood.”

“Please lend us your considerable strength.”

The Chairman turned to leave, only to pause after a step. Then he casually tossed out one last remark.

“Welcome.”

“…”

“Then I will take my leave.”

Once the senior Chinese officials accompanying the Chairman had disappeared, I collapsed into a chair.

Fuck.

If I died, the cause of death would be death by humiliation.

Even if a monster killed me, I would have the cause of death recorded as death by humiliation.

Aagh! Aaaaaagh!

As I screamed in every direction inside my mind, something firmly stepped on my foot.

It was obviously Team Leader Choi, who was sitting beside me.

“Why?”

Team Leader Choi gave a quiet cough.

“Ahem.”

“What is it?”

“Ahem. People. People.”

“Oh.”

I looked around and finally realized that a dozen or so men and women of various races were staring at me inside the underground bunker.

Four of them stood out in particular.

Those people are…

A Chinese man and woman, and two Western men, one tinged green and the other blue.

I could feel it from the moment our eyes met—the enormous energy coiled within their bodies.

Rather than being surprised, I felt that it was only natural. Anyone who knew the identities of those four would have thought the same.

S-rank Hunters.

People whose very existence made headlines. The individuals who stood at the pinnacle of the countless Hunters around the world.

The faces I had grown sick of seeing on television and in commercials were right in front of me.

And now one of them rose and held out his hand.

“Nice to meet you. I’m… Ah, do you not speak English? I can cast translation magic for you.”

I had never expected him to approach me first.

Still dazed, I took his hand and answered,

“No, it’s fine.”

“Oh, listen to that pronunciation. I’d believe you were American.”

He was a middle-aged Black man, a giant well over two meters[1880] tall. His blue eyes gleamed as he asked,

“You seem to know who I am. Am I right?”

How could I not?

I was even more nervous than I had been when facing Chairman Xiao Yang.

“Of course. Magic Johnson.”

The title of Archmage, bestowed on only three people in the entire world.

And among those three, the Black man standing before me—Magic Johnson—was the War Mage, the one most specialized in combat.

I’m actually talking to Magic Johnson. I never thought I’d live to see the day.

As I thought that coming here had been the right choice in more ways than one, the world’s greatest War Mage smiled broadly and spoke to me.

“Haha. Thank you for recognizing me. Actually, I’ve known about you for a while.”

“Y-You know me?”

“Of course. Even my youngest daughter, who started elementary school this year, knows Lord Fuck.”

“…”

Just how far has that damn nickname spread?

I wondered what Lord Fuck would be called in the English-speaking world.

[1880] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

Fuck Guy? Fuck Man?

The thought of Magic Johnson's youngest daughter knowing me by that name did not make me happy in the slightest.

Apparently, I wasn't the only one displeased.

"What an utterly vulgar nickname. Though I suppose it suits a mere A-rank Hunter like you."

The Chinese man who had just turned thirty, or perhaps was about to, watched me with his arms folded.

"Isn't that right, you peninsula bangzi?"[1881]

Team Leader Choi had no chance to stop me.

My voice had already come out like a prerecorded response.

"What the hell are you talking about, you mainland chink bastard?"

[1881] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans; "peninsula" refers to Korea.

Chapter 385

"Isn't that right, you peninsula bangzi?"[1882]

"What the hell are you talking about, you mainland chink bastard?"

A heavy silence fell over the room.

Foreigners like Magic Johnson were using translation magic, but even they couldn't tell exactly what the original slurs *bangzi* and *chink* meant. Team Leader Choi clicked his tongue quietly, while one man's face hardened like stone.

"What?"

"What, asshole?"

"Say that again, bangzi."

"Sure. Chink."

"You fucking—"

"Good. Let's get this straight. I'm a dog. You're a chink."

"…!"

I watched his face twist violently. Just as he was about to shove back his chair and leap to his feet, the woman sitting beside him raised a hand to stop him.

"Enough."

She was a beautiful woman in her early twenties, with the same crisp, refreshing air as a soft drink. Her calm voice followed.

"I'd appreciate it if you both kept this within reason."

Within reason…

I studied her for a moment, then shrugged.

"Well, if you're asking."

One of her eyebrows arched slightly, as though my answer had surprised her.

"I heard you were quite a handful, but you're more agreeable than I expected."

"I have to be. It's you asking, after all."

"So you've fallen for my feminine wiles? Ah, being beautiful is such a burden."

She swept back her long hair with practiced nonchalance, drawing a quiet laugh from me.

"Did you just laugh?"

"You're more entertaining than I expected, Ms. Faye Chen."

Faye Chen. That was her name.

I couldn't let her looks and fresh-faced air fool me into thinking she belonged on the cover of a university brochure. She might never have married, but she was well over fifty.

She was also my senior by decades and one of the heroes of the Great Cataclysm.

[1882] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans; "peninsula" refers to Korea.

“So you knew who I was from the start. Hmm. I thought young people these days wouldn’t recognize me.”

She wasn’t wrong. Compared to other S-rank Hunters, Faye Chen rarely appeared in the media.

There were even persistent rumors that she had changed her identity and was living a new life somewhere out of the public eye.

But I had known about her since I was very young.

“My mother’s been a fan of yours for years. You starred in that romance movie that came out about twenty years ago, didn’t you?”

“Oh, my. That was ages ago. Still, it’s nice to meet someone who remembers it.”

“Would it be all right if I asked for your autograph later? I think my mother would be thrilled if I brought one home.”

“Of course. And from now on, just call me Chen. My full name sounds much too formal. If you want to be even friendlier, you can call me big sister.”

“What? What are you talking about? I looked you up online. You’re five years older than my mother.”

“…You really are a handful. Just as I heard.”

But someone else was being a far greater handful.

“You fucking lowlife—!”

His voice boiled with rage. The man we had briefly forgotten during our conversation glared at me.

“How dare a bangzi from a weak little country look down on me? Do you even know who I am?”

“…Wow. That line was fucking awful.”

Faye Chen propped her chin on one hand and looked between us with interest.

“True. I’ve been wondering for a while now. Do you actually know who this young man is?”

Faye Chen wasn’t the only one waiting for my answer.

Everyone was staring at my mouth except Team Leader Choi, who now looked halfway to enlightenment.

The man huffing like a seven-year-old who had lost an argument. Magic Johnson, the Archmage from the United States. Even the young man from the United Kingdom. Their attendants were no exception.

With everyone watching, I nodded.

“I know. Wu Heixing.”

When it came to media exposure, he competed for first or second place even among S-rank Hunters. There was no way I wouldn’t recognize him.

Wu Heixing—the man who had been picking a fight with me and throwing around the word *bangzi*—stared at me with wide eyes.

“You knew who I was, yet you still dared behave that way?”

“Even a stray dog would know there’s a human piece of shit among the S-rank Hunters.”

“What, what did you say?”

“What? Everyone knows your hobby is getting attention and your specialty is committing crimes, then manipulating the media afterward.”

“…!”

“Come to think of it, didn’t you cause some trouble last year? *The only drug my country allows me.* You posted a raid photo on your official social media with some bullshit like that, then got caught using actual drugs a month later. Was it marijuana?”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Don’t stop me, Team Leader Choi.”

“It wasn’t marijuana.”

“What?”

Team Leader Choi abruptly cut in and calmly corrected the Taekyung Wiki.

“It was cocaine and methamphetamine.”

“Oh, I see. Thank you for clarifying.”

“Think nothing of it. Now that things have gone this far, what is there left that I can’t say?”

Look at that enlightened expression.

Leaving behind Team Leader Choi, who had renounced all worldly attachments and was preparing to ascend to immortality, I flashed Wu Heixing a broad smile and continued.

“Damn, how did you think of planting foreshadowing like that? This bastard is at least Wu Heishunwon. *Purple Raid.*”

“What, what did you say?”

“Come to think of it, there was something else. Five years ago, you got caught drugging and sexually assaulting someone at some club called Burning Moon or whatever. How did you get acquitted? Under Chinese law, it wouldn’t have been strange if you’d been executed two or three times over.”

“…!”

“I heard a rumor that you’re the son of one of the Communist Party’s highest-ranking officials. Did you buy your way out with money and power? Look at this clever bastard.”

“Shut your fucking mouth! How dare a lowborn bangzi speak to me like that!”

Wu Heixing’s face turned scarlet as he roared. Someone who had been silently watching the whole affair finally spoke.

“You’re noisy.”

An arrogant voice flowed smoothly through the room.

“Frivolous and vulgar. I hear you are descended from a noble Chinese family. Did your elders neglect to teach you proper etiquette?”

Wu Heixing bit his lip when he recognized the speaker.

“Y-You’re…”

“*You’re?*”

Beneath neatly styled brown hair, faintly green eyes swept slowly over Wu Heixing, then moved away.

“William.”

At the young man’s summons, the graying middle-aged man standing behind him stepped forward.

His shoes were spotless, and the creases of his suit were sharp enough to cut. He stood tall, surveyed the room, and spoke in a pleasant baritone.

“Everyone, rise and show proper respect to His Highness Prince Felix Alexander Louis, Duke of Cambridge, Earl of Strathearn, Baron Carrickfergus, Knight of the Order of the Garter, and Knight of the Order of the Thistle.”

Duke of Cambridge, Earl of Strathearn… Fuck, why does he have so many titles?

At any rate, Prince Felix added solemnly, “You may all simply call me His Highness Prince Felix.”

“…”

“…”

Look at everyone’s faces. They couldn’t have looked more uncomfortable if they tried.

Of course, the finest expression of all belonged to Wu Heixing, who had just called me lowborn.

Understandable. When it came to social standing, how was he supposed to beat British royalty?

“So, this is…”

“Ah.”

Prince Felix regarded the flustered Wu Heixing and nodded as though something had just occurred to him.

“I see. Are you a stutterer?”

“A-a stutterer?”

“If not, why can’t you speak properly? Did your family neglect to provide you with speech training?”

Long live His Highness the Prince.

I didn’t even need to step in. Having the third person in line to the British throne inject carbonated water straight into my veins made me fizz all the way down to my duodenum.

I was grinning so widely my mouth might split when Prince Felix suddenly turned his gaze on me.

“You there.”

“Hm? Are you talking to me?”

At my question, the middle-aged man behind Prince Felix opened his mouth.

“When His Highness Prince Felix Alexander Louis, Duke of Cambridge, Earl of Strathearn, Baron Carrickfergus, Knight of the Order of the Garter, and Knight of the Order of the Thistle deigns to address you—”

“That will do, William.”

Prince Felix raised a hand, silencing the parrot mid-sentence, then regarded me benevolently.

“I have personally set aside my dignity and intervened because I have always believed that the barriers between social classes must be broken down.”

“…?”

“What does it matter whether one is lowborn or noble? Beneath God, we are all equal. So do not take that man’s words too much to heart.”

What the fuck is this supposed to mean?

I was momentarily speechless. Team Leader Choi leaned over and whispered discreetly.

“I believe he thinks you really are lowborn, Mr. Jin.”

“…!”

Has that prince bastard lost his mind?

As I stared at Prince Felix in disbelief, he slowly rose and extended the back of his hand toward me as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

“Come now.”

“Come now? What is it this time?”

The middle-aged man, who might have been either a secretary or a parrot, smiled with satisfaction.

“Kiss the back of his hand and express your gratitude for the benevolence His Highness Prince Felix Alexander Louis has shown you.”

“…”

Are these people completely insane?

Did these fucking eighteenth-century bastards take a time capsule here or something?

My head reeled. Then Team Leader Choi’s message magic reached my ear.

—No.

I answered through Sound Transmission.

—What do you mean, no?

—Whatever you're thinking, no. Just smile and let it go. Prince Felix is already famous for being an eccentric.

—Wouldn't he become even more famous if I broke the back of his hand right now?

—No. Absolutely not!

—Just the back of his hand. Or maybe only one finger.

—I said no!

I hadn't known that a message spell could convey this much emotion. Team Leader Choi must have been desperate in his own way.

Fine. He's a British prince. I can't do anything about that.

I was swallowing my anger when—

"Hey, Lord Fuck."[1883]

What now?

I looked warily at Magic Johnson, who had suddenly approached me.

I had never expected much from Wu Heixing, who was famous for his anti-Korean sentiment and all kinds of trouble. But the joy of seeing S-rank Hunters I had only watched on television in person was gradually running out.

"…No, please. Don't call me Lord Fuck. Use my name. Would you like it if I called you Dickson instead of Johnson?"

"Hmm. Now that you put it that way, I see your point. Jin, then?"

"That's much better. But why?"

"It's nothing special. I was just wondering—are you really not planning to kiss the prince's hand?"

That sounds pretty special to me.

I was dumbfounded and immediately asked back.

"Of course not. What is this, the Middle Ages? Would you want to do it if you were me, Johnson?"

"I would."

"What?"

Enlightenment struck me like a flash of lightning.

I had completely forgotten. Magic Johnson was an American national hero—and a national gay icon.

Time magazine's choice for "the world's most influential LGBT person" was making a serious suggestion to me.

"So I was thinking I might express my gratitude to the prince in your place, Jin."

"…"

He really knows how to dress it up.

[1883] "Lord Fuck" renders *ssi-beol-jwa*, an online nickname Taekyung received after accidentally swearing during a broadcast.

But unlike Magic Johnson, Prince Felix quietly withdrew the back of his hand.

“Beneath God, we are all equal. Such antiquated customs ought to disappear. Magic Johnson, I shall accept your kind offer another time.”

“…”

Is that really something the same bastard who held his hand out to me a minute ago should be saying?

Faye Chen, who had been listening, muttered as though she found it absurd.

“My, he’s shameless. He may be one step above Wu Heixing, even if he hasn’t actually committed any crimes.”

“He’s still better than Wu Heixing. That guy should’ve been executed if the law had been followed.”

“That’s true.”

The arrival of one heavyweight after another had reduced Wu Heixing to a cowering nobody, but sparks flew from his eyes.

“Y-you—you fucking bangzi!”

“Stop going on about bangzi already. Even the national anthem gets tiring by the second verse. The same goes for me going easy on you.”

“…You’re going easy on me? Someone like you?”

He sounded genuinely unable to comprehend the idea, so I nodded.

“Yeah. I’m sure of it now.”

I had a rough idea of Wu Heixing’s level, but he had no idea what kind of person I was.

A fight began with sizing up your opponent. This one was over before it even started.

“So stop picking fights and back off while I’m still asking nicely. Let’s just focus on our own jobs.”

“You’re merely an A-rank Hunter, yet you’ve grown arrogant because Chairman Comrade favors you! You don’t even know how high the sky is—!”

“Ah.”

So that was why he had started this bullshit the moment we met.

The reason was so obvious and childish that a derisive laugh escaped me.

“Damn. You’re way too fucking old for this to be cute.”

“…!”

“What are you going to do? You wanted all the Chairman’s attention and expectations for yourself, but some Korean guy came along and stole them.”

“You…”

Realizing I had seen straight through him, Wu Heixing flushed with shame and rage.

By now, everyone in the room was watching us. He must have felt every contemptuous gaze boring into him.

And when people like him found themselves in a situation like this…

They always crossed the line.

My prediction proved correct.

His fingertips slid almost imperceptibly toward his sword hilt.

Broad-minded Chairman Xiao Yang had not asked anyone present to disarm, offering his trust instead. But that consideration was about to become poison to Wu Heixing.

Draw it. Don’t hesitate.

No matter how reckless I seemed, I still observed the bare minimum of propriety.

Until now, I had held back only because I had come to help China at the Chairman’s request. If Wu Heixing drew his weapon, I would finally have an excuse to fuck him up within reason.

That’s it. More. Keep going.

As though I were controlling him, Wu Heixing’s hand crept closer to the sword hilt.

Just as his fingers were about to close around it—

Step. Step.

Several sets of footsteps echoed down the corridor beyond the silent underground bunker.

Wu Heixing’s hand froze at almost the exact moment the tightly shut door opened.

The instant I saw the man who entered alongside Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu, Wu Heixing vanished completely from my mind.

“I’m rather late. Have I kept everyone waiting?”

He had bold, sharply defined features that looked as though they had been painted with a brush, and a powerful build that even his clothes couldn’t conceal.

He looked like a middle-aged man barely into his forties, but beneath that skin lurked an old tiger and a cunning snake.

Lee Jungryong.

Our eyes met, and a deep smile spread across Lee Jungryong’s lips.

Chapter 386

“I’m rather late. Have I kept everyone waiting?”

Lee Jungryong swept his gaze over the gathered people. Some faces were familiar; others he was seeing for the first time today.

Magic Johnson and Faye Chen, whom he had encountered several times during the Great Cataclysm. The young British prince. And China’s problem child.

Whenever his eyes met theirs, the S-rank Hunters gathered in the underground bunker greeted him first.

“Long time no see, Lee. You’ve grown even more attractive since the last time I saw you. Every time I see you, I feel like confessing my love.”

“Please restrain yourself, Magic Johnson. You’re not my type. Faye Chen here might be, though.”

At Lee’s breezy reply, Faye Chen swept back her long hair.

“Oh my. I had no idea you felt that way about me, Mr. Lee. What a shame I found out so late.”

“What’s there to regret? You’re still in your prime.”

“Thank you for saying that, but the young people will laugh if they hear you. They’ll ask what those old folks think they’re doing.”

“Is that really how it is?”

Under Lee’s gaze, Wu Heixing hurriedly waved his hands in denial.

“N-no, Mr. Lee. Of course not.”

“I’ve heard a great deal about you. Exceptionally talented and, hmm, a young man who’s honest about everything.”

“Th-thank you.”

Wu Heixing bowed his head, looking humbled by the honor.

He normally had *bangzi*—a derogatory term for Koreans—practically glued to his lips, along with his anti-Korean sentiment. But he lacked the nerve to show that side of himself in front of Lee Jungryong.

A bead of cold sweat rolled down the back of Wu Heixing’s neck.

“I’d heard you were coming, but I never expected you to actually appear.”

“Of course I had to come. When a neighbor is in trouble, shouldn’t we help?”

“It’s an honor to meet you, Mr. Lee.”

Even Magic Johnson and Faye Chen, heroes born of the Great Cataclysm, could not compare to Lee Jungryong.

He was the sworn brother of Cheon Taemin, known as the Jesus of the twenty-first century and the savior of the world. He was also the de facto head of the Ares Guild.

One of the most powerful Guilds in the world. And one of the three strongest among all S-rank Hunters.

Lee Jungryong.

Anyone who stood before him owed him the proper respect.

Even the overbearing Wu Heixing was no exception. Neither was the prince, despite his royal blood.

“Nice to meet you. A pleasure to meet you, Jungryong Lee.”

“Ah. So you’re that prince.”

“How impudent—”

Prince Felix raised a hand to silence his secretary, then inclined his head with elegant restraint.

“Felix. You may call me Felix. It is permitted.”

The Korean that came through the translation device was awkward, and his tone was hard to place.

But with those words, Felix Alexander Louis, third in line to the British throne, made the difference between Lee Jungryong and everyone else perfectly clear.

He had gone so far as to let Lee omit the title *His Highness*.

Of course, Lee Jungryong did not care in the slightest.

They’re still just brats.

The only people Lee acknowledged were Magic Johnson and Faye Chen.

Whatever their personalities, Wu Heixing and Prince Felix were both hailed as geniuses. But in Lee’s eyes, they were nothing more than chicks that had only just learned to walk.

And the people who truly grated on his nerves were elsewhere.

The Peace Guild.

Lee’s gaze shifted to one side. A deep smile spread across his lips as he looked at the two people standing there in silence.

“I seem to be running into you two rather often these days. Have you both been well?”

At Lee’s greeting, Jin Taekyung and Choi Minwoo glanced at each other and shrugged.

“Not really.”

“Not particularly.”

“…?”

What?

Lee Jungryong unconsciously faltered.

It had been less than a month since he had last seen them. Yet something had changed dramatically in the way they treated him.

Hostility.

That was it.

The unmistakable hostility and wariness he had sensed from them before were gone.

As Lee studied the two people who stood before him with such calm expressions, he soon realized why.

They've grown stronger. So much stronger than before that there's no comparison.

There was no doubt about it. Choi Minwoo's qi was far greater and more refined than before—so much so that Lee found himself wondering how he had managed to grow this much in such a short time.

And the other one, Jin Taekyung—

…What is this?

Lee felt it through his skin and sixth sense: the immense qi contained within Jin Taekyung's body, and the profound stillness in his eyes.

It could mean only one thing.

He crossed the wall.

The shock hit Lee like a blow to the back of the head. He had to struggle with all his might to keep his agitation from showing.

How?

Jin Taekyung had undoubtedly been powerful before. Perhaps he had even stood above the countless A-rank Hunters throughout the world.

He had defeated two Named Monsters by himself. It was only natural that the public and the media had clamored about the birth of a new S-rank Hunter.

But Lee Jungryong had known that Jin had not yet crossed the wall. He had known that it would take the young man a very long time to overcome the barrier blocking his path and become a true powerhouse.

And yet—

How can something this absurd happen?

This went beyond mere surprise.

As Lee met Jin Taekyung's calm gaze, he remembered emotions he had long forgotten.

Anxiety. Impatience.

It was the first time Lee Jungryong had felt such unease since taking complete control of the Ares Guild.

Only a few months ago, Jin had been someone he found laughable and irritating. Yet that same man had now awakened anxiety and impatience within him.

You bastard…

The smile on Lee's lips vanished without a trace. Wei Fenghu regarded his hardened expression with puzzlement.

"Mr. Lee? Is something wrong?"

"…It's nothing."

"Hmm. Then may we begin the meeting?"

Lee Jungryong nodded without a word, but his gaze remained fixed on one person.

Leaning at an angle against the back of his chair, Jin Taekyung muttered as if to himself.

"Well, it looks like quite a big deal to me."

"…!"

"Or not. Whatever."

Without realizing it, Lee Jungryong clenched his fist.

The meeting in the underground bunker continued for a long time.

The Monster Wave had caused at least hundreds of thousands of casualties over the past week. That alone made it an enormous natural disaster and an unmistakable state of war. It was only natural that every decision had to be made with the utmost caution.

"Therefore, we should divide our forces into five armies and gradually pressure the enemy…"

Someone interrupted Wei Fenghu as he continued with a grave expression.

"Minister of National Defense Comrade."

"Speak, General Liao."

The middle-aged man called General Liao wore a uniform weighed down with medals. Stroking his beard, he began to speak.

"Listening to the Minister of National Defense has become too frustrating for me to remain silent. If we keep dragging our feet like this, how long will it take us to deal with those monsters?"

Wow…

His tone was unbelievably obnoxious.

He was speaking that way to Wei Fenghu, the Chairman's right-hand man and the highest-ranking man with real power in the military.

As though he had read my thoughts, Team Leader Choi sent me a message spell.

> ㄴ **Choi Minwoo:** The Communist Party has factions of its own. General Liao comes from the highest pedigree of the Crown Prince Party, the Communist Party's largest faction, going back to his grandfather's generation. It rivals the Shanghai Gang, to which Chairman Xiao and Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu belong.
>
> ㄴ **Jin Taekyung:** The Crown Prince Party and the Shang…what?

> └ **Choi Minwoo:** …If we must rank them, it means the Crown Prince Party is number one and the Shanghai Gang is number two.
>
> └ **Jin Taekyung:** Oh.

Until now, I had assumed that the Communist Party operated under a strict one-party system. Apparently, they fought among themselves just as fiercely.

> └ **Jin Taekyung:** But is that really allowed? If Chairman Xiao pointed at someone and said, "That man is harmful," wouldn't they behead him in Tiananmen Square?
>
> └ **Choi Minwoo:** They do it because they're allowed to.
>
> └ **Jin Taekyung:** …Well, when you put it that way, I don't have much to say.
>
> └ **Choi Minwoo:** The factions reached an agreement. During the Great Cataclysm, the Chairman from the Crown Prince Party made so many mistakes that they couldn't very well keep holding power.
>
> └ **Jin Taekyung:** Ah. Pingping?[1884]
>
> └ **Choi Minwoo:** Yes. Pingping.[1885]

That damn Great Cataclysm changed all sorts of things.

While I listened to Team Leader Choi's explanation, General Liao, a pedigreed Crown Prince Party brat, came out with a brilliant proposal.

"Let's use nuclear weapons."

"…?"

"…?"

"Let's submit a formal request to Chairman Xiao and launch dozens of nuclear warheads across Sichuan. Wouldn't that solve everything nice and cleanly?"

"…"

"…"

Would you look at this nuclear-crazed lunatic?

Everyone, myself included, stared at one another in disbelief.

Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu's expression was the most impressive of all. He looked like a man itching for a handgun as he answered.

"Rejected."

"Why? Are you ignoring me because I'm not part of the Shanghai Gang?"

"Say something that makes sense. Something that makes sense! What about the people who are still alive or haven't been harmed? What about the land that would be reduced to a wasteland?"

[1884] "Pingping" is a mocking nickname derived from Xi Jinping's given name.

[1885] "Pingping" is a mocking nickname derived from Xi Jinping's given name.

"The sacrifice of the few for the many is unavoidable!"

I didn't know about the rest, but the man himself looked like an oxhead.[1886]

Magic Johnson, who had been listening quietly, suddenly spoke in his deep voice.

"The damage from a successful nuclear attack would be bad enough, but what will you do if they use teleportation magic to move the warheads? To Beijing, for example."

"That's why we have an Archmage like you…"

"Me? Our opponent isn't an ordinary Lich. If that Arch Lich is more skilled at magic than I am, it could cause a truly irreversible catastrophe. Similar things already happened several times during the early days of the Great Cataclysm, remember?"

"B-but even so… A sacrifice of this scale…"

"Hey. Murderfucker."

Bang!

That startled me.

Magic Johnson shot to his feet, his bronzed muscles rippling.

"Stop it. I like East Asian men, too. I might have to punish you."

"…!"

"…!"

That's the scariest threat I've ever heard.

General Liao's face turned deathly pale as he looked around for help. But the officials who seemed to belong to his faction avoided his gaze, as did Wu Heixing, his last possible line of defense.

So that's how this gets resolved.

His opponent was an American national hero—and a national gay icon.

Everyone seemed desperate not to become one of the East Asian men Magic Johnson liked.

Of course, General Liao's relentless stream of bullshit had played a major role as well.

"Enough, both of you. Especially you, General Liao. Stop spouting such utter nonsense."

Under Wei Fenghu's direction—the Chinese man who had just put down that chink—the meeting proceeded quickly.

After gathering the opinions already raised and settling the arguments, Wei Fenghu secured everyone's agreement before speaking with a weary expression.

[1886] In Korean, *so* can mean both "small" or "lesser" and "cow." Taekyung twists General Liao's maxim about sacrificing the lesser for the greater into an insult.

“We will assign the six S-rank Hunters here to six separate fronts. Under the official force organization, each front will receive three Army and Air Force divisions, along with Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department.”

Three Chinese divisions and the Public Security Armed Forces Department.

I didn’t know exactly how many people that meant, but the sheer manpower would be enormous.

When it came to the number of Hunters a country possessed, China was always competing for first or second place.

Of course, the enemy won’t be any pushover either.

The estimated casualties alone numbered in the hundreds of thousands.

If the Arch Lich had resurrected the dead as undead…

Then an almost unimaginable number of enemies would be waiting for us.

“This concludes the meeting. Everyone, move out as soon as possible.”

Wei Fenghu said the exact troop numbers and force organization would be provided in writing. Just as everyone rose from their seats, it happened.

Come see me for a moment.

Someone’s voice pierced my ear.

It wasn’t a message spell. It was unmistakably Sound Transmission.

Chapter 387

It was already deep into the night by the time we left the underground bunker.

I drew a deep breath, letting the cold air seep into my lungs. As I gazed up at the star-filled sky, thinking of Sichuan in the Murim somewhere out there, a small hand tapped me on the shoulder.

“Coming with me? I’m thinking of having a light drink.”

“Now?”

“Yeah. Just us.”

It was Faye Chen. Two other members of that “us” stood behind her.

One of them spoke in a voice brimming with dignity.

“Lady of the East, might there be any Romanée-Conti among the wine we shall share?”

“I’m no noblewoman, but of course I have some. Do you like wine, Prince?”

Prince Felix answered with a displeased look.

“I told you to call me His Highness Felix, not Prince. And I enjoy wine in moderation. Especially the 1945 Romanée-Conti.”

“I don’t have the 1945 vintage.”

“Then I must decline. I shall be leaving.”

Was this guy actually insane?

As Prince Felix disappeared with his attendants, Faye Chen turned toward the one person left behind.

“You’re coming, right, Johnson?”

Magic Johnson grinned, baring his snow-white teeth.

“I’m sorry. Unfortunately, I think I’ll have to put it off until next time.”

“Why?”

“I might be deployed to the front tomorrow. I’d feel more at ease if I at least prepared my spells with Memorize.”

As expected of an Archmage. Heroes of the Great Cataclysm didn’t become heroes for nothing.

Deeply impressed by Magic Johnson’s attitude, I spoke up.

“I don’t think I can go right now either.”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“You’re neither a prince nor an Archmage.”

“…That’s not how this works.”

Unbelievable. Never mind her completely unreasonable demands—that

ajumma[1887] was really something else, suggesting drinks at a time like this.

"You just cursed me in your head, didn't you? You called me a thoughtless ajumma[1888] for wanting to drink at a time like this."

"…How did you know?"

"Oh my, look at how pointlessly honest this boy is."

Faye Chen poked the tip of my nose with one long finger. She looked like a beautiful woman in her early twenties, but she was actually older than my mother. It felt strange.

"Why don't you find someone else? Mr. Lee, perhaps…"

"Lee?"

Faye Chen tilted her head slightly. Lee Jungryong had long since disappeared with the Ares Guild members he had brought with him.

"Hmm. He's rather difficult to deal with. He wasn't like that during the Great Cataclysm, but he's turned into such a slippery snake. I can never tell what he's thinking."

She had an excellent eye for people.

Faye Chen cast a sidelong glance at another candidate disappearing into the distance before continuing.

"Wu Heixing. He's far too rude. Drinking with him would ruin the taste."

I gazed at Wu Heixing's back as he headed into the deserted forest and answered.

"Nothing we can do, then. You'll have to drink another time."

"No. These are exactly the days you drink."

"…?"

"It might be our last chance."

"Ah."

I thought I understood, at least somewhat, why Faye Chen was looking for a drink.

War wore people down. It also brought unexpected farewells in the form of death.

This was her own eve-of-battle ritual after losing countless comrades during the Great Cataclysm.

By the time this crisis was over, one of us might have crossed the river from which no one ever returned.

"Well, since things have turned out this way, I'll have to find a new target. Right, handsome young man?"

"I told you I'm not going."

Faye Chen stared at me incredulously.

"Do you have no shame? I meant that young man over there, not you."

[1887] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

[1888] *Ajumma* is a familiar Korean term for a middle-aged or married woman.

The handsome young man Faye Chen had singled out—Team Leader Choi—nodded readily, contrary to my expectations.

"If you're inviting me, it would be my honor."

"Uh, Team Leader. You're really going?"

"Of course. When will I ever have another chance to share a drink with Faye Chen? Besides, there are many things I'm curious about."

Faye Chen giggled.

"I thought you were only handsome, but you're sweet with words, too. So, what are you so curious about?"

"The Equipment you're wearing right now. Where did you buy it?"

"…That's your question?"

"Yes."

"You're quite a handful yourself."

Magic Johnson burst into hearty laughter as he watched Faye Chen heave a deep sigh.

"Ha ha. Miss Chen, shall we all go have a drink together, then?"

"All together? Johnson, didn't you say you weren't coming?"

"I did. I have no interest in drinking alone with a woman. But if an attractive man like Mr. Choi here joins us, that changes things."

"…"

"I like men. East Asian men in particular."

"R-right. Let's go."

As expected of *Time* magazine's choice for the world's number-one most influential LGBT person.

I sent Team Leader Choi a Sound Transmission as he was dragged away, stiff as a board.

—Call me if anything happens.

Team Leader Choi looked back at me with mournful eyes, like a cow being led to the slaughterhouse, then disappeared with the two S-rank Hunters.

I looked around before setting off.

This was the direction.

After walking along the dark path for some time, keeping out of sight, I stopped in the pitch-black darkness and spoke.

"Come out."

After a brief silence, someone's voice drifted from the darkness.

"…Not bad."

Rustle.

Wu Heixing emerged with the sound and looked me up and down.

“How did you know?”

“What kind of question was that?” I answered flatly.

“You might as well ask me what one plus one is. That would be harder.”

“Hmm. So you were more capable than I expected.”

“Don’t pretend to praise me now. It’s obvious you’re trying to pull some cheap trick.”

“…!”

I had hit the nail on the head. Wu Heixing’s face flushed bright red.

In a way, he was remarkably easy to handle. I knew he was well into his thirties, but it was hard to believe anyone could be this simple-minded at that age.

“I-it wasn’t like that. I sincerely…”

“You sincerely think I’m a bangzi.[1889] You were pissed because some random Korean who isn’t even officially an S-rank Hunter was getting all the attention instead of you. So you picked a fight with your usual one-dimensional bullshit, but nobody reacted well, and that bangzi[1890] turned out to be less of a pushover than you expected. Right?”

I kept firing off words like a machine gun without giving him a chance to answer.

“So now you’re throwing out a few compliments you don’t mean and making friendly gestures, trying to pull some kind of trick… Wait. Is any part of what I just said wrong?”

“…”

“Yeah, I’ve met plenty of guys like you. I’ve been smacked in the back of the head so many times that even my useless brain finally started turning.”

When I gave him a contemptuous look, the red-faced Wu Heixing began to stammer.

“I wasn’t trying to pull some other trick.”

“Then what? If you’re thinking of becoming friends with me, fold that idea up neatly and put it away. If you stand next to shit, the smell gets on me too.”

“…!”

“But what are you doing right now?”

At my quiet question, the hand creeping toward his sword hilt stopped dead.

“Don’t draw it. You’ll get hurt.”

Wu Heixing looked at me with conflicted eyes before blurting out a question.

“You already knew everything… So why did you come along so willingly?”

“Because I had something to ask.”

“What?”

I looked straight into Wu Heixing’s eyes.

[1889] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

[1890] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

"Sound Transmission. Right?"

"…!"

His rigid expression was answer enough. I'd thought it might be possible, but this was still surprising. Scratching the back of my head, I muttered,

"I guess it is. Well, this is the mainland, so I suppose various martial arts could have survived here. An internal-energy cultivation technique, for example."

"W-what are you talking about? That was message magic…"

"Oh, please."

A snort escaped me at the sight of him scrambling to make excuses.

Other people who had never encountered martial arts might not be able to tell the difference, but he couldn't fool me.

Come see me for a moment.

What had reached my ear near the end of the meeting had unquestionably been Sound Transmission.

I had accepted an invitation I could easily have ignored because Wu Heixing himself had sent it.

"H-how did you know?"

"Why? Was it some secret no one else knew?"

I stared at the flustered Wu Heixing and continued.

"I thought it might be possible, but it's still fascinating. Didn't you people wipe out all the martial artists during that whole Cultural Revolution[1891] business? I'm impressed that martial arts survived even through that."

"Shut your mouth!"

"Oh, right. You said your family was powerful. Did the highest-ranking Communist Party officials quietly smuggle it out by abusing their positions?"

"…"

His expression sank instantly. I must have been right.

As a foreigner, I didn't know how serious a problem this was, but I understood the value of an internal-energy cultivation technique—in other words, what was called a mana cultivation technique in the modern era.

If this were the Murim, there would've been a bloodbath.

He had been caught secretly hoarding a golden calf like that. Naturally, Wu Heixing wasn't reacting well.

"It would be wise never to speak of what you just said again."

"I had no particular intention of doing so, but your tone is pretty damn offensive."

Wu Heixing glared at me with venomous eyes.

"Would you still act like this after learning who my father is?"

[1891] The Cultural Revolution was a political movement in China from 1966 to 1976 during which historical and cultural traditions were attacked.

“I don’t know who your father is, but he sounds like he might have been a former Red Guard.”[1892]

“…!”

“Wasn’t your father the one who went around with a sledgehammer in his youth, smashing Confucius’s tomb?”

“You fucking bangzi[1893] bastard!”

Flash!

With a furious shout, he shot forward.

An Aura Blade—no, Sword Force—surged from the straight sword already drawn from its sheath and hurtled toward my throat.

Whoosh!

The cool wind scattered my hair. I bent backward until my waist nearly touched the ground, letting the Sword Force pass overhead, then sprang upright and drove my knee into his chin.

Crack!

Teeth and blood flew through the air. As Wu Heixing staggered, I seized both his arms and whispered in his ear.

“I told you not to draw that sword.”

Sizzle. Crack!

“Aaaaaaargh!”

The powerful Scorching Yang Qi coursing through my hands shattered his armor and burned his flesh.

Wu Heixing’s scream struck the qi barrier I had spread around us and went no farther.

“You bastard!”

Whoosh!

This guy had even learned fist-and-foot martial arts. Unlike his shoddy sword technique, this was fairly sharp.

Of course…

Compared to the Murim, the quality of his martial arts is much lower.

Slightly disappointed, I reached out.

Boom!

Internal energy collided with internal energy.

His leg, whipping toward my waist, stopped dead.

Wu Heixing’s eyes trembled with shock and disbelief.

“H-how?”

[1892] The Red Guards were groups mobilized during China’s Cultural Revolution to attack people and traditions deemed politically suspect.

[1893] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

"I'm good."

I grabbed his ankle and slammed him into the ground with all my strength.

Whoosh! Boom!

Once more.

Whoosh! Boom!

Again. And again. And again.

Boom! Boom! Craaash!

The ground churned, and rocks and trees were ripped free.

By the time I stopped using him as a human pickaxe, Wu Heixing lay spread-eagled in a huge crater, looking as though his soul had left his body.

"Still, you've got a sturdy body, so you're not hurt that badly."

"Urgh… ugh…"

"Hey, are you crying?"

"Uuuugh…"

He was completely out of it.

Clicking my tongue, I bent down and searched his pockets.

After rummaging through the pouch enchanted with spatial expansion magic for a while, I finally found what I was looking for.

"Ah, here it is. A high-grade potion."

"…No, wait. A top-grade potion? What the hell, you bastard?"

I stared in surprise at the sprawled-out Wu Heixing. Even for an S-rank Hunter, carrying something like this around was absurd.

High-grade potions were rare enough, but top-grade potions appeared maybe once or twice a year.

Their almost unreal price aside, they were so scarce that even people with money couldn't get their hands on one.

I've only ever seen these online, and now there's one right in front of me.

After a moment's hesitation, I slipped the top-grade potion into my Inventory. Then I searched his pouch again, found a high-grade potion, and poured it over him.

"I've got my settlement payment, so I'll let you off here. You've got plenty to be worried about yourself, so if you go around telling people about what happened today… You know what'll happen, right?"

"Ugh… uuuugh…"

“Okay. We’ve reached a settlement.”
Just as I finished wrapping things up neatly, the phone in my pocket vibrated.
A short text from Team Leader Choi was waiting for me.

> **Team Leader Choi**
> └ **Team Leader Choi:** Mr. Ji nTaekyung, pl ease come quickly.

“…”
No, Johnson.

Chapter 388

"Hey. Hey."

Tap. Tap-tap.

Someone prodded Wu Heixing in the side with the tip of a foot. He barely managed to open his eyes, and a large figure looming over him swam into view.

"Uhhh…"

"I've got something urgent to take care of, so I have to get going. If anyone comes by, make up a convincing story, will you?"

"Ugh… uuuugh…"

"I poured a potion over you, so quit acting like you're dying, you bastard. Keep it up and I'll call Magic Johnson over to make you moan for real. See you!"

Whoosh!

Leaving behind a parting remark that made Wu Heixing's ass ache just from hearing it, the man sped away and vanished in an instant.

It was only ten minutes or so later that Wu Heixing, still lying spread-eagled on the ground, finally spoke in a voice boiling with rage.

"Jin Taekyung…!"

His broken bones and torn flesh had healed thanks to the high-grade potion, but it couldn't heal the pain etched deep into his bones—or his wounded pride.

How?

He couldn't believe it. No matter how agitated he had been, how could he—an S-rank Hunter—have been toyed with so thoroughly?

The fact that Jin Taekyung had seen through his martial arts was shocking, but Wu Heixing took even greater offense at the defeat itself. He had always been fiercely proud of the power he possessed.

Me? Me, of all people?

Wu Heixing had been born with the destiny of a Hunter.

As an infant, his potential had been confirmed through an extraordinarily expensive mana aptitude test, and his family, part of the highest ranks of the Chinese Communist Party, had spared no expense in supporting him.

Enormous wealth and power accumulated through corruption. Raised in the finest environment with the best possible support, Wu Heixing awakened as an A-rank Hunter at the age of twenty. Ten years later, he achieved the astonishing feat of becoming an S-rank Hunter.

And yet…

Then why? Why did I lose to some bangzi[1894] bastard from that tiny country?

[1894] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

A strange light flashed in Wu Heixing's eyes as he glared up at the pitch-black night sky.

His gaze held anger, jealousy, and a trace of fear toward the power Jin Taekyung had displayed.

They were emotions Wu Heixing had been sickeningly familiar with for more than a decade.

He shouted at the man who was now nowhere to be found.

"Was this your doing? Are you trying to torment me even after death?!"

The public and the media cursed Wu Heixing as an irredeemable delinquent even as they praised him as a genius born of Zhonghua.[1895] But a tiny handful of people, Wu Heixing included, knew the truth.

There was another—the true genius. And it was precisely because of his genius that they had kept him hidden from the world.

"Answer me, Lei Fei!"

With his overwhelming strength and noble character, Lei Fei had been an insurmountable wall to Wu Heixing.

How flustered—and delighted—Wu Heixing had been when he first heard that Lei Fei had disappeared.

But after only a week, another wall had appeared.

A wall named Jin Taekyung.

"Gaaaaaaaah!"

The bushes shuddered beneath his thunderous cry.

"I know that feeling well."

At the quiet voice of someone who had approached without making a sound, Wu Heixing sprang upright like lightning.

"Who are you?!"

"That hurts. I thought we already knew each other."

Step.

A man emerged from the darkness. Wu Heixing's eyes widened.

"You're…?"

Beneath the faint moonlight, Lee Jungryong continued with a smile.

"I believe we have something important to discuss. What do you say?"

"…!"

Ding.

[1895] *Zhonghua* refers to China or Chinese civilization; here it is used as a patriotic name for the nation.

SYSTEM

Circulate Your Qi completed!
The realm of Fire Gate Divine Technique has risen slightly!

By the time I finished gathering my qi and opened my eyes, the world outside was growing bright.

As though it had been waiting for that exact moment, the Skeleton Warlord immediately spoke.

> "Wicked human. Are you finally awake?"

"I wasn't asleep, you idiot."

> "Drinking before a battle. Tsk, tsk."

"It's not like alcohol can make me sick, so shut up."

Drinking too much caused alcohol toxins to build up in the body, but any decent martial arts master could drive them out with ease.

And with my formidable Scorching Yang Qi, I had even less to worry about.

Come to think of it, I really did drink a lot. I polished off every bottle Faye Chen brought over on her private jet.

I had definitely gone there to stop Magic Johnson, but I wasn't entirely sure how things had ended up that way.

> "But human, how long do you intend to remain in this stuffy place?"

"I was planning to leave anyway."

I checked the time. Five-thirty in the morning. It was about time to get ready.

After packing my things in the hotel room assigned as my temporary lodging, I went down to the lobby and found Team Leader Choi drinking coffee.

"Oh, Team Leader."

"...There you are."

One glance revealed dark circles beneath his eyes. His skin, usually kept so immaculate that it didn't have a single blemish, looked rough and dry.

"Did you not sleep?"

"If you were in my position, Mr. Jin, would you have been able to?"

"..."

Fair point.

The sight I had witnessed after racing over in response to the most desperate emergency text in the world last night had been nothing short of horrific.

“Hey, Choi. It’s just a drinking game. Come on, be cool and do it once. What do you say?”

“Faye Chen! Please help me, Faye Chen!”

“Hmm… Sorry, but it’s a drinking game. The king’s command is absolute. Isn’t that the rule?”

“Even so, a kiss?! I’ve never played a drinking game before! You didn’t even explain the rules properly!”

“Oh, whatever. Number two will kiss number three on the cheek. That’s my command.”

“Choi. Stay still. I don’t want to cast a binding spell on you.”

“This is absurd… Mr. Jin! Over here, Mr. Jin!”

“Jin. Don’t interfere. I don’t want to cast an offensive spell on you.”

If I had arrived even one minute later, a catastrophe would have occurred.

I had been forced to down an enormous amount of alcohol in exchange for rescuing Team Leader Choi, but I didn’t regret it in the slightest. After all, I had been promised fair compensation.

“You remember the promise you made yesterday, right? About adjusting my settlement ratio.”

“…I remember. Nine to one.”

Team Leader Choi glared at me coldly.

“How could you do that in such an urgent situation? Are you even human?”

“Then go give him a nice, passionate kiss right now. Number two is coming over as we speak.”

He might have been number two, but when it came to being gay, he was number one in the world.

Team Leader Choi spotted Magic Johnson—a huge Black man who had just entered the lobby—and sprayed out his coffee.

“Pfft! Please, please hide me.”

“I think it’s already too late.”

The moment I finished speaking, Magic Johnson spotted us and waved a hand as big as a cauldron lid.

“Hey, gays!”

Wasn’t it supposed to be *guys*? He must have said it wrong… right?

As Team Leader Choi and I stared at him in disbelief, Magic Johnson approached and burst into hearty laughter.

“Don’t look at me like that. I got a little too excited yesterday and played the tiniest prank.”

"…You were really excited?"

"Ah. That came out wrong."

"Please watch what you say. You startled me."

"Haha. Anyway, something came up yesterday."

"…What came?"

"Huh? No, not *that* kind of coming."

"Please watch your words. You really startled me."

"Please, both of you, stop. I'm afraid someone will hear you."

Looking utterly resigned, Team Leader Choi downed the rest of his coffee and turned his head.

A group of people had entered through the hotel's front doors and were walking toward us.

"It's time to leave, gentlemen."

Wei Fenghu, the Minister of National Defense, stood at the head of the group. His voice was rigid with tension.

At his signal, an elderly military general handed each of us a folder.

"What are these?"

"Information on your assigned areas and the forces stationed there. Of course, we have already sent them the necessary information and contacted them in advance. From here, you will travel aboard your designated jets."

This was one of the conveniences of living in a modern age with cutting-edge technology.

A short while later, we followed Wei Fenghu to the temporary airfield, where several familiar faces waited amid heavy security.

"Did you sleep well, young people?"

"…"

"You're late."

Faye Chen greeted us while stretching her arms high overhead. Perhaps because of what had happened yesterday, Wu Heixing kept his eyes lowered without a word, while Lee Jungryong wore a strange smile.

The Skeleton Warlord, safely stored in my Inventory, spoke in a displeased voice.

> "That human is unpleasant for some reason. This commander does not like him one bit."

"I agree."

Faye Chen raised an eyebrow at my quiet mutter.

"Hm? What did you say?"

"Nothing. By the way, where's Prince Felix?"

“He left just before dawn. Apparently, a battle signal came from the area he was assigned.”

“…I see.”

Another battle, less than twenty-four hours after arriving.

The word *war* suddenly made a corner of my heart clench tight.

Our nationalities and upbringings were different, but knowing that human beings like me were being slaughtered somewhere made my heart heavy.

“Hey, young man.”

“Yes?”

Faye Chen had been staring at me intently. She reached out and gave me a light tap on the shoulder.

“Relax your shoulders. If they’re that heavy, how are you supposed to swing your spear?”

“…”

“Don’t blame yourself, and don’t be impatient. You can’t take responsibility for every death.”

Responsibility.

I thought about it for a moment before answering honestly.

“…I don’t know. I’m not sure I can do that.”

“Well, you certainly drank yourself senseless yesterday for someone who feels that way.”

“That was…”

“I know. I’m joking. People like us forget the burden for a little while that way. Our lives might end tomorrow—or even today.”

The content didn’t match her bright voice. The hero who had made her way through the Great Cataclysm with every inch of her body looked up at the sky.

“Ah. Perfect weather for a fight.”

She turned and walked lightly toward the jet, which was ready for takeoff.

Then she left us with one quiet remark.

“Let’s all… see each other alive.”

Her back disappeared inside the aircraft.

Magic Johnson gazed up at the sky for a moment with an oddly sentimental look, then suddenly spoke.

“Hey, Choi.”

“Yes?”

“Relax your butt, too.”

“…”

“No, your shoulders. Let’s see each other alive again.”

That sounded suspiciously like his true feelings slipping out.

Magic Johnson laughed heartily at Team Leader Choi's wary look and boarded the aircraft after Faye Chen.

Wu Heixing followed as though fleeing the scene. Finally, Lee Jungryong, the last one remaining, swept his strange gaze over Team Leader Choi and me.

"Take care of yourselves. It would be a shame to die in a place like this, wouldn't it? Especially at such a young age."

What a way for an old man to talk.

It was one hell of an ominous remark.

Team Leader Choi's face hardened, so I smiled and answered in his place.

"That's right. Unlike certain people, we're too young for anyone to call our deaths a good passing."

"…!"

"If you do kick the bucket, I'll make sure to send a generous funeral contribution."

"I'll be counting on it."

After a brief silence, Lee Jungryong tossed out that final remark and led the Ares Guild members away.

Now only Team Leader Choi and I remained.

I stretched as hard as I could, then patted him on the shoulder.

"Let's go, Team Leader."

"Yes. We should."

"No need to be nervous. Relax your butt."

"…"

"…That was a joke. I'm sorry."

One more joke and he looked ready to kill me.

I was cautiously watching Team Leader Choi's expression as I boarded the aircraft when it happened.

"Unit—attention!"

A booming shout erupted behind us.

Wei Fenghu stood at attention and saluted us, his half-gray hair fluttering in the wind.

The people filling the airfield followed his lead and raised their hands in salute.

It was a gesture of respect for the heroes going to fight for their families and friends.

Their salutes remained raised until the jet's door closed and the aircraft dwindled to a distant speck in the sky.

Good grief.

With a send-off like that, how could my shoulders not feel heavy?

I leaned back in my seat, suddenly exhausted.

Then—

Crackle. Crrrackle.

"…swer. Respond. This is…"

A static-filled radio transmission suddenly came from the cockpit, accompanied by an alert that pierced my ears.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A Sudden Quest, The Desperate War Situation, has been generated.
You cannot refuse this Quest. Arrive as quickly as possible and defeat the enemies!

"…"

Damn it. That's my life, all right.

I let out a deep sigh, then shouted toward the cockpit.

"Sir, floor it!"

"Where are they?"

The speaker was an old man in his eighties. His face was covered in wrinkles and age spots. His aged body was no longer what it had been in his youth, but his eyes held even greater power than they had back then.

Even through the holographic screen, the old man's powerful gaze could be felt. Wei Fenghu swallowed hard before answering.

"They have all departed, Chairman Comrade."

"How is the situation at the front?"

"Because of the magical interference disrupting communications and the barriers, we cannot easily determine the enemy's movements. However, we are doing everything possible to track them."

"If the S-rank Hunters arrive…"

"With their strength, they should be more than capable of turning the tide."

"Don't jump to conclusions. Do not let your guard down for even a moment. The lives of countless people depend on our decisions."

"Yes. I will keep that in mind."

After the brief communication with Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu ended, Xiao Yang, Chairman of China, sat alone in the vast conference room and sank into thought.

How did things come to this?

It was a catastrophe without precedent since the Great Cataclysm. Despite pouring in vast amounts of manpower and money, they had been unable to stop the monster army centered around the Arch Lich.

He had wanted to avoid causing panic if at all possible, but if they delayed any longer, the opportunity might disappear forever.

That was why Xiao Yang had come here today despite the countless objections within the Communist Party.

“They’re ready.”

“…Connect me immediately.”

At his secretary’s words, Xiao Yang opened his eyes.

Holographic figures began appearing one after another in the empty seats of the spacious conference room.

Fourteen people of different races and genders.

No—fifteen, including Xiao Yang.

Each of them was the leader of a nation, and all belonged to a single body.

The United Nations Security Council.

In a grave voice, the elderly Chairman called the emergency meeting to order.

Chapter 389

It was a day when the cold snap had finally eased.

Students at last freed from the college entrance exam were busy either preparing to retake it or having fun, while office workers with dark circles under their eyes packed onto public transportation.

Then, amid that peaceful, ordinary routine, a bombshell no one had seen coming dropped.

> **Urgent Breaking News—Major Announcement from the United Nations Security Council**

The video, just over thirty minutes long, began with Chairman Xiao Yang staring gravely into the camera.

“I stand before you as the ninth Chairman of the People’s Republic of China and a member of the United Nations Security Council to speak about the massive Monster Wave unfolding in Sichuan Province.”

It was a bombshell that seized the world’s attention and shook all of Asia.

One day passed, then two, then three. Even after four days, the situation showed no sign of calming down.

There had been countless incidents and disasters since the Great Cataclysm, but the Monster Wave in Sichuan Province was unprecedented in scale.

Chairman Xiao Yang of China officially declared martial law, and with the approval of the United Nations Security Council, peacekeeping forces were deployed to the front.

The entire world was watching.

The Asian countries bordering China were especially on edge.

Korea was no exception. Once again, the Hunter Issues section of the country’s largest online forum was boiling like a cauldron over hot coals.

Here’s a summary of the situation so far.

There isn’t anyone here who hasn’t watched the Security Council’s major announcement video, right? If there is, go die somewhere. This is a genuine emergency. The supreme leader up north has probably already watched the whole thing on iTube and is lurking on this board, too.

Anyway, so many insect bastards kept asking someone to summarize a situation their own lives depended on that I finally got fed up and wrote this.

1. An unexplained massive Wave occurred in Sichuan Province. Current estimated casualties: at least 300,000.

Of course, that figure is from a week ago, so there's probably no comparison with the number now. At this point, I doubt accurate statistics are even possible.

2. The Chinese government stepped in, but the scale was far crazier than anyone expected.

A monster army numbering at least in the tens of thousands has gathered around something called an Arch Lich.

The People's Liberation Army and Air Force got absolutely wrecked, while more than two thousand Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department have gone missing. Magical interference cut off communications and neutralized satellite surveillance, so they can't even confirm whether those Hunters are still alive.

3. The Chinese government secretly contacted several countries and hired a number of S-rank Hunters to suppress the situation as quickly as possible. United Nations peacekeeping forces were deployed to the front two days ago, and they're fighting desperately.

The Security Council is posting updates on the fighting, so anyone interested can check them here.

(Link attached.)

Everything below this is just my personal opinion, so feel free to skip it.

4. Anyone with a properly functioning brain already knows this, but the current situation isn't merely serious. Mainland China is practically hell on earth.

They're pulling every useful Hunter they can find and sending them to the front. Other Gates are being neglected as a result, and their mana levels are becoming unstable. Prices are also hyperinflating across the board.

The truly frightening thing is that if the front collapses and the monster army advances beyond Sichuan… I'll leave the rest to your imagination.

5. So go to the supermarket and stock up on emergency food before we're all completely screwed. Of course, I'm not telling you to hoard supplies and profiteer.

6. It felt like a shame to end it here, so I'm throwing in some national pride.

Our Lord Fuck and the Ares Guild's Jung Dragon[1896] are active on the front. Keep hyping them up as hard as you have been.

Teh end.

[1896] "Jung Dragon" is a nickname for Lee Jungryong; *ryong* means "dragon" in his name.

Within hours of being uploaded, the post passed 100,000 views, and the comments caught fire as netizens following the situation weighed in.

> ㄴ **Best comment:** The situation really is as serious as the post says, but the author is setting the mood way too hard lol. They say S-rank Hunters are fighting alongside 100,000 ordinary Hunters. What's there to worry about? Is the military just sitting around?
>
> ㄴ Yeah. They're sitting around in maintenance depots right now.
>
> ㄴ ...?
>
> ㄴ Didn't you watch the news? All the Chinese military's Equipment broke down this time, exposing the largest military procurement corruption scandal ever. They say it's worth at least tens of trillions of won.[1897] Apparently, more than one or two divisions are stuck in place.
>
> ㄴ Huh. This sounds like something I've heard a lot before.
>
> ㄴ Please change the canteens already, you motherfuckers. I got out last year, but why did the water in my canteen still taste like it came from Normandy? [1898] After one sip, I couldn't even tell whether my name was Kim Cheol Soo or James.
>
> ㄴ Corporal Kim. Tonight's dinner is boneless pollock braised in sauce.
>
> ㄴ I'm not eating, fuck.
>
> ㄴ Anyway, the military being stuck because of broken Equipment is a problem, but they've got manpower to spare, so they're probably fine. Hunters are the only ones who can actually inflict meaningful damage on monsters, after all. The real problem is something else.
>
> ㄴ What?
>
> ㄴ The monster population has broken through 100,000.
>
> ㄴ ??
>
> ㄴ ?????
>
> ㄴ What do you mean, 100,000? Don't talk bullshit.
>
> ㄴ It's not bullshit. It's official information announced by the United Nations Security Council. Follow the link in the post and check it yourself. It was posted five minutes ago.
>
> ㄴ Wow... fuck.
>
> ㄴ Judging by the reaction to the comment above, I guess it's true. Holy shit.

[1897] Tens of trillions of won means roughly 10–99 trillion won, or about $7.1–71 billion and €6.5–64 billion.

[1898] Normandy refers to the Allied landings in France during World War II. The comparison suggests that the canteen is decades old.

> ㄴ No. That's just because it's all in English and I don't understand what it says. I'm running it through Gargle Translator right now.
>
> ㄴ Is this guy insane?
>
> ㄴ Hey, but if the number of monsters really has broken through 100,000, isn't that a huge problem? Until now, the largest Monster Wave we'd ever seen hadn't even reached a thousand monsters, had it?
>
> ㄴ Naturally, this Wave wasn't anywhere near this large in the beginning. The problem is that there's an Arch Lich over there. Even an ordinary Lich appearing would be a major incident, but that one is an apex named Monster unknown even to academia. Practically speaking, most of the monsters fighting right now are undead resurrected by the Arch Lich.
>
> ㄴ Arch Lich: "Kaioken, times one hundred."[1899]
>
> ㄴ Then can't we just kill the Arch Lich? If most of the monsters are undead, killing the controller should end everything, right?
>
> ㄴ ???????
>
> ㄴ Who's going to kill the Arch Lich, and how, you fucking idiot? The guy who uses an Aura Blade with his keyboard has nothing but a mouth.

A fierce debate raged on.

Some commenters watched from a safe distance, as though the whole thing were a fire across the river, while others took the crisis seriously.

Even as doomsday predictions and blind optimism ran rampant, new information continued to pour in.

> ㄴ **Best comment:** Security Council official report: The front in the east-west sector was breached one hour ago. Fortunately, Faye Chen arrived with reinforcements and stopped the damage from spreading.
>
> ㄴ Holy shit, it's real.
>
> ㄴ If it's the east-west front, isn't that where Wu Heixing is?
>
> ㄴ Yeah. That Chinese junkie.
>
> ㄴ But why did it get breached? He's an S-rank Hunter.
>
> ㄴ Because he's a Chinese-made S-rank Hunter.
>
> ㄴ Ah…
>
> ㄴ If Faye Chen hadn't been there, this could've become a real disaster. Maybe it's because Faye Chen is a well-made Hunter forged by the Great Cataclysm.
>
> ㄴ Faye Chen is Hong Kong-made. Her parents had Hong Kong citizenship.

[1899] Kaioken is a power-multiplying technique from *Dragon Ball*.

> ㄴ Do you work for the comment quality-control committee? That was fucking clear.
>
> ㄴ While we're at it, does anyone have news about the Korean Hunters?
>
> ㄴ Jung Dragon[1900] has taken charge of the northern front and is gaining the upper hand. I heard Lord Fuck won two or three times on the western front, but there hasn't been any news since then, so I guess he's maintaining the current situation.
>
> ㄴ Hmm… I'm not worried about Lee Jungryong, since everyone knows how skilled he is, but is Lord Fuck safe? He's still an A-rank Hunter, after all.
>
> ㄴ ?? LOL
>
> ㄴ LOL
>
> ㄴ There's still an innocent idiot who treats Lord Fuck like an A-rank Hunter, lol. As a current A-rank Hunter, all I can do is laugh. That Jin Taekyung guy is just a monster, lol.

> ㄴ Hey, hey, h-hey!! The Se-Security Council just posted an update on the w-western front!
>
> ㄴ Oh, news about Lord Fuck. It's been a while.
>
> ㄴ You sound frantic as hell. What does it say about the western front?
>
> ㄴ It says it was breached?
>
> ㄴ Huh?
>
> ㄴ Huh?
>
> ㄴ What are you talking about? Don't tell me Lord Fuck died…?
>
> ㄴ Wait. What the hell does this mean? I'm going to watch it again. It's on the main page, so check it yourselves.
>
> ㄴ Shit. I'm suddenly freaking out. I'm going in right now.
>
> ㄴ Go go go go go.

The netizens who had been gleefully hammering out comments rushed to the United Nations Security Council website.

The sudden flood of visitors overloaded the site, leaving them waiting for ages. When the announcement finally appeared on the main page, they could only doubt their own eyes and ears.

"…What is that?"

A map showed the opposing lines in the standoff against the monster army. The front formed an oval, with the western side driven deep into it like the tip of an awl.

[1900] "Jung Dragon" is a nickname for Lee Jungryong; *ryong* means "dragon" in his name.

> ㄴ I just checked. It really was breached.
>
> ㄴ Is Jin Taekyung dead? How bad are the casualties?
>
> ㄴ No, the monsters' side was breached.
>
> ㄴ ??
>
> ㄴ ???
>
> ㄴ The breakthrough was so fast that the updates couldn't keep up.
>
> ㄴ ...Does that even make sense?
>
> ㄴ Shut your mouth and pull down the shutters. Today is the Lady of the House's memorial day...[1901]

The battlefield where a fierce clash would soon erupt was packed. An endless wasteland stretched before us, filled with more monsters than I could count.

The wind carried their thick killing intent and stench toward us.

"Fuck me. They sure gathered a lot of them."

Team Leader Choi, standing beside me, answered my mutter.

"No matter how many we kill, there's no end to them."

It was the fourth day since we had been deployed to the western front and the fighting had begun in earnest. There was no trace left of Team Leader Choi's usually immaculate appearance.

Covered in blood and dust, he regarded me with calm, somber eyes.

"When do we begin?"

"Well, we'll have to hear what our little commander thinks. Right?"

The last question wasn't directed at Team Leader Choi.

The twenty-one-year-old "little commander" who had remained at my side the entire time, Xiao Shen, answered.

"I'll follow Teacher Jin's orders!"

His sparkling eyes made me snort.

"You're still calling me Teacher? You were the one who told me to drop the formalities first. I told you to call me hyung[1902] instead."

"A-are you really sure that's all right?"

"I told you it was fine as long as you were okay with it. But is this really all right in front of your men? You said you're getting promoted to major general now, didn't you?"

Xiao Shen shook his head at lightning speed.

[1901] Korean netizens call for a tavern's Lady of the House and drinks to celebrate a surge of national pride. Saying it is her memorial day reverses that celebration.

[1902] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close.

"No problem at all! H-hyung, hyung!"[1903]

He was frighteningly calm in battle, so I had no idea why he stammered so much in everyday life.

I looked at the Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department lined up behind him. There were roughly a thousand of them.

Their fever-bright eyes shone with admiration and awe for the strong.

Of course, Xiao Shen stood out above all the rest.

"Give the order, h-hyung."[1904]

"The order, huh?"

I suddenly looked up at the sky.

An eagle circled overhead on enormous outstretched wings.

I had a good feeling today, too.

"Follow me. Just as you've done until now."

"…!"

"Right now."

I stepped forward as I answered.

Crack.

The ten thousand geun[1905] of force concentrated in my toes split the ground like a spiderweb and made it cave inward.

Then, in the next instant—

Boom!

With a deafening roar, I shot forward like a streak of light.

Flamefire Path.

The cold wind heated into a scorching blast.

The earth, the wind, and the scenery streaked past. Then a tremendous roar erupted behind me.

"Charge! Charge!"

"Descendants of Zhonghua![1906] People! Sweep them all away!"

"Waaaaaaah!"

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Kyaaaauuuuu!

The shouts of humans and the howls of monsters rang across heaven and earth. A tremendous vibration shook the foundations of the world.

At the threshold of that chaos, I swung the White Flame with all my strength.

[1903] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close.

[1904] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close.

[1905] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb); ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg (about 13,200 lb).

[1906] *Zhonghua* is a patriotic term for China and Chinese civilization.

Fwoooosh!

The Extreme Yang Force surging from the spearhead cut through everything in its path.

Chapter 390

Whoosh!

Hot blood sprayed from severed necks in the wake of the Force.

I stepped on the body of an ogre collapsing like a bundle of straw and soared high into the air. Sunlight warmed the back of my neck.

Perfect weather for a fight.

It was noon, and the battlefield was a wasteland without a single tree.

My shadow fell across the thousand or so monsters gathered below, the sun at my back. Then I plunged toward them, spear sweeping down.

Heavenly Strike.

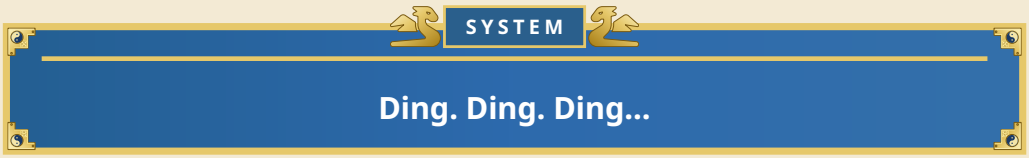
Boom!

The fire dragon's claw raked the earth.

A deafening roar split the sky. The ground caved in several meters[1907] deep, sending dirt and shattered stone flying in every direction.

A whirlwind of hot air that erupted in the middle of the battlefield transformed into blades and swept across the monsters.

Fwoooosh!



Green blood pattered down through the dust-filled haze as System notifications announced the monsters' deaths.

I gave my hand a casual sweep, dispersing the cloud of dust. The monsters beyond it stared at me in a daze.

"Chirrik?"

"Krruk?"

Their eyes seemed to ask what the hell was happening. I drew a deep breath and shouted with internal energy behind my voice.

"Sweep them away—!"

And then—

"Waaaaaaaaah!"

Along with an ear-deafening roar, more than a thousand Hunters who had arrived before I knew it descended on the monster army like a wave.

Crunch!

Wham!

[1907] Several meters is roughly 10–16 ft.

Watching the monsters crumble without any chance to resist, I became certain of one thing.

We've won this battle.

The farming was over. Now it was time to harvest.

I headed toward the Twin-Headed Ogre that appeared to be the boss monster.

For the sake of my precious EXP. No—for the sake of minimizing allied casualties.

"That one's the leader! Ranged unit!"

"Hey, hey! Hands off! I'll handle it, so don't touch a single hair on its head!"

I swear to heaven, I didn't have even the slightest ulterior motive.

…

Well, on second thought, there was probably no need to swear.

"You despicable human. Your scheme to claim the spoils is plain to see. You never even tried to hide your greed while slaughtering my army!"

"Shut up and do your job, will you? Hurry up and make the undead slaughter their own kind."

"I was already going to. Grow, skeletons, gro—huh?"

"What's wrong?"

"Why isn't my power working? Is this a bug?"

"…Where did you even pick up a word like that?"

The increasingly modernized Skeleton Warlord answered in a dejected voice.

"It seems the Arch Lich's control grows stronger the deeper we go. Ah, a commander without an army! I cannot express the depth of my sorrow. At this rate, I'm as good as dead!"

…

What did this bastard think he was?

I was tired of reminding him that he was already dead. Sighing inwardly, I charged toward the leader.

"It's a crushing victory! Another crushing victory!"

Xiao Shen shouted, his face flushed red. Team Leader Choi and I had already seen this more than ten times, so by now we simply took it in stride.

Well, I suppose he has reason to be excited.

It had taken barely two hours to annihilate an army of more than a thousand monsters.

And we had done it without a single death. It really was a monumental victory. Under the circumstances, it would have been stranger not to get excited.

“Our only casualties are twenty-three severely wounded and thirty lightly wounded. Ah, this is incredible…!”

Xiao Shen trembled like a puppy desperate to pee and looked at me with shining eyes.

“How can this happen every time?”

“Hmm. Maybe it’s because I’m strong.”

Team Leader Choi gave me a mildly incredulous look.

“Why?”

“Wouldn’t most people say something modest at a time like this? That they were lucky, for example?”

“Most people would. But what can I do when it wasn’t luck? I really am that strong. Right, Shen?”

Xiao Shen nodded at tremendous speed.

“That’s right! You’re the best, hyung[1908]!”

“You rascal. You’ve turned flattery into an art form.”

…

Team Leader Choi shook his head as he watched us play off each other.

“What?”

“Nothing. Then again, this is very much like you, Mr. Jin.”

What was that supposed to mean? Somehow, it sounded unpleasant.

I shrugged and turned to Xiao Shen.

“More importantly, what about headquarters?”

“Ah, I contacted them before the battle began.”

By “contacted,” he meant that he had sent several Hunters under his command ahead as messengers.

In a world like this, one might wonder why anyone was still using messengers, but there was no choice. With magic making communication and satellite surveillance impossible, our only options were to run like hell or use vehicles.

At least we still had various modern conveniences, including flares.

“They’ll take a while, then.”

“They were already following behind us, so it shouldn’t take too long.”

“You’re probably tired, but pitch some tents and let the men rest. The battle ended quickly, but fighting still takes everything out of you.”

“Shouldn’t we take care of at least the large monsters ourselves? They’d probably be difficult for headquarters to move…”

“That’s a fair point.”

By headquarters, he meant the military forces traveling with us.

[1908] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

The Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department, myself included, would defeat the monsters at the front. Then the military forces following behind would “clean up” the area and the monster corpses.

I called it cleaning up because their goal wasn’t to collect byproducts.

It was cleaning in the literal sense. The army assigned to the western front spent most of its time cutting up dead monsters and transporting the remains to the rear so they couldn’t be resurrected as undead.

“Um, hyung[1909].”

“Yeah? What is it?”

“I was too embarrassed to mention this before, but… it seems some of the high-ranking officers have been saying various things.”

“Saying what?”

Xiao Shen studied my expression before whispering cautiously.

“They’re a little dissatisfied with the role they’ve been assigned…”

“…?”

What the hell was he talking about?

It took me quite a while to understand what Xiao Shen meant. After a long, heavy silence, I spoke with a sinking feeling.

“Don’t tell me they’re saying they want to stop cleaning up monster corpses and win some glory of their own.”

“Yes.”

“Would you look at these crazy bastards.”

The curses came spilling out on their own. Soldiers on the other fronts were dying every day, and these people were sick of cleaning up monster corpses?

Team Leader Choi, who had been listening quietly, spoke in a calm voice.

“Don’t be surprised. A chink did what chinks do.”

That hardly seemed like something he should say in front of nearly a thousand Chinese people, but Chinese people and chinks were, strictly speaking, different races.

Xiao Shen, the representative of all good Chinese people, had turned red with embarrassment.

“I-I’m sorry. But as far as I know, it isn’t all the officers. Only some of them are dissatisfied.”

“Only some of them. Right. But there’s one thing I’d like to know…”

I frowned and pointed over Xiao Shen’s shoulder.

“Does that ‘some’ include the man coming this way?”

[1909] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

In the distance, more than a hundred armored vehicles and tanks were approaching us, kicking up clouds of dust.

Rattle, clunk!

The vehicle driving along the ruined road bounced up and down. Through the window of the military vehicle I was sitting in, I began to see wrecked rice paddies and fields, along with collapsed homes scattered here and there.

Once the cleanup was finished, I—or rather, *we*—set off for a nearby small city.

“Haha, you’ve truly worked hard, Mr. Jin!”

A paunch even his tightly fastened belt couldn’t hide. A bald crown gleaming beneath the sun.

If not for his military uniform and the three stars on his shoulders, I would never have had any reason to meet the middle-aged man sitting before me.

“I contacted the higher-ups this morning, as it happens. Your victory report has thrown not only the United Nations Security Council but the entire world into an uproar! I don’t know what it means, but apparently Korea calls today the Lady of the House’s memorial day…”[1910]

I had heard enough of his nonstop nonsense. Unable to take any more, I cut him off.

“I don’t care whether the Lady of the House is dead or alive. May I ask you one thing?”

“M-Mr. Jin?”

General Liao, commander in chief of the 13th Group Army of the Chengdu Military Region, which comprised seven divisions and brigades, looked at me uneasily.

“Why—why are you acting like this? Did something happen?”

“I heard something strange today, so I’m a little on edge.”

“Who dared upset you, Mr. Jin? Ask me anything.”

“Right. What I wanted to ask was…”

I continued while staring at General Liao’s greasy, glistening face.

“I heard some officers are extremely dissatisfied because they want to distinguish themselves. I was wondering if you knew anything about that.”

“Ahem.”

So he did know.

The fact that he had known and still done nothing about it was so absurd that I felt strangely calm.

[1910] *Jumo* is a traditional Korean tavern hostess. General Liao’s reference to her “memorial day” turns a call to celebrate with drinks into a reference to the anniversary of her death.

Still, he was technically an ally and a three-star general from another country. I asked in the calmest, politest tone I could manage.

“Could I see the faces of those fucking bastards?”

“Ahem!”

“I mean, what kind of lunatics throw a fit about wanting to win glory at a time like this? It’s not as if they’ll go out and fight themselves. They’ll put ordinary soldiers in front of them and wave their command batons around from the rear, won’t they?”

“Ahem!”

“What the hell do they mean, they’re sick of cleaning up monster corpses? Why? Have they seen so many that they’ve grown fond of them and decided they want to become corpses too? Maybe they won’t come to their senses until they actually fucking die. Goddamn bastards.”

“Ahem!”

“If there are officers like that, tell them to come see me. I’ll put Equipment on them and send them to the very front. They’d make perfect meat shields—”

I suddenly stopped in the middle of my tirade. Cold sweat was pouring from General Liao’s forehead like water from a sprinkler.

“…”

This man was one of those lunatics too.

I had suspected he wasn’t an ordinary madman ever since he started babbling in that underground bunker about whether or not to launch nukes. Now it was clear that he was insane on an entirely different level.

“…General. Are you in your right mind?”

“I-I mean, we need to show what we can do as well. Just a little…”

“What more do you need to show anyone? We’ve been advancing steadily without taking casualties. The Hunters clear the path ahead, and the army follows behind to clean up and rescue civilians. We’re doing a good job. What more are you trying to prove?”

Crack.

At the sight of me popping my knuckles, General Liao hurriedly waved his hands.

“Now, now! Let’s not use informal speech with each other. Considering both my age and my rank, I’m not someone who should be treated this way by you, Mr. Jin.”

“How about I treat you to a bowl upside the head?”

“Wh-what did you say?”

“Nothing. You heard me wrong. Anyway, I understand. Don’t entertain any foolish ideas. From now on, we advance slowly, minimize casualties, and rescue civilians. Understood?”

“…”

Why was this man reacting like that?

The moment I saw General Liao's eyes rolling around instead of answering, a chill ran down my spine.

No way…

"Have you already given the order?"

"W-well, the thing is, I'm currently implicated in a military procurement corruption scandal. This is the point where I need to accomplish something on my own…"

"You fucking bastard!"

Bang!

My kick tore the armored door from its hinges. The driver in the front seat hurriedly slammed on the brakes.

Screeeech!

"Eek!"

General Liao curled into a ball and trembled as he answered in a stammer.

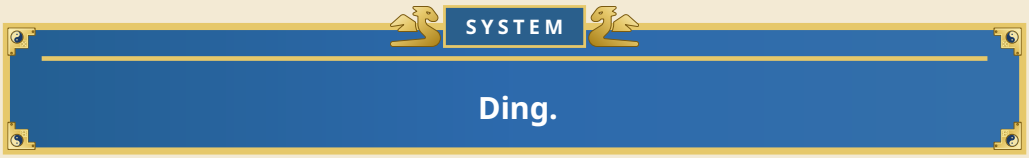
"I-I thought there might be monsters in the small city we're heading toward, so I deployed some of the Public Security Armed Forces Hunters we were holding in reserve…"

I didn't need to hear any more. Before I could press him for details, a tremendous roar rang out from the city, now close ahead.

Boom!

A massive explosion. Flames and smoke shot into the sky.

And then—



A System notification announced a Sudden Quest.

Chapter 391

Zhang Wei, commander of the Sichuan Province Public Security Armed Forces Department's 2nd Company, had remained in the rear, and the operation had made him uneasy from the very beginning.

Go ahead with the army and occupy the city? That's different from Colonel Xiao's orders.

His doubts had only deepened when they deliberately bypassed their allies fighting up ahead and continued their advance.

"Colonel Wang, are you certain our regimental commander agreed to this operation?"

The middle-aged senior officer frowned at Zhang Wei's question.

"Why do you want to know?"

"No matter how I look at it, something feels wrong. Our regimental commander clearly ordered us to conserve our strength in the rear and guard headquarters…"

"Ah, you mean that little regimental commander."

Zhang Wei's expression hardened at the officer's mocking tone toward Xiao Shen.

"Regimental Commander Xiao Shen holds the same rank as you, Colonel Wang. And he'll soon be promoted to major general."

"That child knows nothing about the world. He was simply lucky. As if awakening as an A-rank Hunter wasn't enough, he even made the promotion list thanks to that Korean bastard's exploits. Considering how quickly he's risen through the ranks, I wonder if he has some useful guanxi[1911] in political circles."

"He may be young, but he's exceptionally capable. He's also highly respected—he's close enough to us to treat us like brothers."

The senior officer stroked the command baton in his hand.

"I know perfectly well that Hunters don't care about rank. But this is wartime. This order came from General Liao, the commander."

"From the commander himself…?"

"That's right. So if you don't want to obey, you may turn back now. Just remember that doing so would constitute disobedience."

"…!"

"We're merely trying to speed up our advance. Given the circumstances, it's unlikely there are any monsters left behind, but if there are, we'll wipe them out and rescue any civilians in danger. That's all. Understood?"

Zhang Wei remained silent for a long moment before nodding and withdrawing.

[1911] *Guanxi* refers to influential personal connections and relationships, especially those used within social or political networks.

The Public Security Armed Forces Department was generally treated as a separate organization outside the military, but this was wartime. Defying General Liao, commander of the western front, would not be a wise choice.

"What did he say?"

Zhang Wei answered his subordinate's hushed question.

"He said it's an easy operation, so we should shut up and follow him. If we refuse, it's disobedience."

"Do you believe him?"

"If you mean the first part, of course not. But the second part is probably true. What do you think?"

"Of course I don't believe him. That bastard Colonel Wang has no ability of his own. He only made it this far because of his guanxi[1912] with the Crown Prince Party. Everyone says he's General Liao's obedient dog."

"And this order came from that very General Liao. Even if something stinks, we have no choice but to endure it for now."

"…Damn it."

"But Colonel Wang might be telling the truth. Most of the monsters in the surrounding area should be fighting our allies. With our current forces, we can handle a few stragglers."

Zhang Wei looked around.

In addition to the hundred Hunters, including himself, they had more than twenty tanks and five hundred infantrymen. Three attack helicopters flew overhead, scouting their surroundings as they advanced.

Please, let there be no serious casualties.

Perhaps Zhang Wei's wish reached the heavens, because what he feared did not happen.

They entered a small town near Suining with every sense alert. Monsters had devastated the place, but the ruined downtown was utterly silent.

The occasional goblin or Orc sprang out at them, but none posed any real threat.

"Kieeeek!"

Slash!

After killing a dozen or so monsters at the head of the column, Zhang Wei relaxed a little.

"Even monsters of different species are appearing separately. They must have strayed from their groups."

"Just as I expected. What did I tell you?"

[1912] *Guanxi* refers to influential personal connections and relationships, especially those used within social or political networks.

The officer's arrogant tone grated on him, but this was still preferable to the alternative.

Zhang Wei silently nodded, only to stop short at the senior officer's next words.

"You want us to split up?"

"That's right. Under these circumstances, we should find the survivors as quickly as possible."

"But, Colonel Wang, we haven't even been inside the city for an hour. We should advance a little farther toward the center before—"

"Watch your insolence."

"Excuse me?"

"You Hunters may be better at fighting, but I'm several steps ahead of you when it comes to tactics. I currently hold command authority, so shut your mouth and follow my orders."

"…!"

"Didn't you hear me? Shall I give the order to your men myself?"

"…I'll do it."

"You have a detailed map, I assume. We'll meet in the central square in two hours."

The officer gave Zhang Wei an obnoxious smile and was about to climb into an armored vehicle when—

Whoooosh! Boom!

Zhang Wei blinked blankly.

He wiped his face with one hand, and his palm came away covered in sticky blood.

It was unmistakably human, a vivid crimson. The officer's body, its upper half gone without a trace, toppled from the armored vehicle.

Thud.

A suffocating silence fell.

Zhang Wei was the first to recover.

"Everyone, prepare for battle—!"

"Monster! A monster has appeared!"

"Tank!"

"The regimental commander has been killed!"

The Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department were the first to react to those shouts. The soldiers took a moment longer to grasp what had happened.

And waiting for them, already thrown into utter chaos by the sudden death of their commander, was an even more horrific death.

Whoooosh!

A single sound tore through the air.

A beam of light shot forward at an invisible speed and swept through the soldiers advancing in orderly ranks and files.

Boom-boom-boom!

It burst dozens of people like balloons before finally piercing the armored vehicle moving under infantry escort.

The streak of light punched through the vehicle's hardened shell and bored deep inside.

The moment Zhang Wei saw it, he roared like thunder.

"Everyone, get clear!"

But before his voice could reach them, the deafening roar that erupted in the next moment swallowed everything.

BOOM!

The armored vehicle erupted in a flash of red and a cloud of black smoke. Hundreds—thousands—of fragments became blades that tore through everything around them.

Countless soldiers and lower-ranking Hunters who had failed to react in time collapsed like bundles of straw.

Their lifeless bodies did not so much as twitch.

"…!"

"W-what the hell…?"

Zhang Wei bellowed at the people frozen like statues.

"Spread out! Everyone, spread out! Get as far away from the tanks and armored vehicles as possible!"

But the soldiers, experiencing combat for the first time in their lives, had gone rigid. The unseen enemy did not let their confusion go to waste.

Whoooooosh!

The sound of death came again.

This time, however, there was more than one streak of light.

Boom! Boom-boom-boom!

"Aaaaaagh!"

Flames surged upward, and screams flooded the air.

The more than twenty armored vehicles and tanks were rendered useless in no more than an instant.

The three attack helicopters circling overhead were also reduced to countless fragments and crashed to the ground.

Boom! Clatter-clatter-clatter.

Amid a horrific scene that could only be called a sea of corpses and blood, Zhang Wei felt a chill run down his spine.

At least A-rank monsters. And there aren't just one or two.

Ironically, it was the most accurate judgment Zhang Wei made that day.

Sssssss.

Between dark alleys and collapsed buildings. Atop the roof of a building still engulfed in flames.

Ten figures that had appeared like black mist stared down at the hundreds of surviving humans with burning violet eyes.

When Zhang Wei saw them mounted on warhorses that had been stripped to the bone, a word escaped his lips like a groan.

"…Death Knights."

Knights who had once been noble, only to be corrupted by black magic.

The very Death Knights who had vanished alongside the Lich after the Great Cataclysm had appeared.

Ten of them.

The first word that came to Zhang Wei's mind was *death*.

Is this where it ends?

Death Knights were beings that surpassed A-rank monsters.

A hundred Hunters and a military force still remained, but Zhang Wei already knew.

There was no escaping the net they had cast.

But…

"I have no intention of dying quietly."

Zhang Wei was not the only one who felt that way.

Unlike the soldiers, who were too frightened even to hold their guns properly, the Hunters of the Public Security Armed Forces Department raised their weapons with determination in their eyes.

"You don't have to go this far."

One of the platoon commanders answered Zhang Wei's quiet words bluntly.

"And you're allowed to?"

"I'm sorry. I shouldn't have brought you here."

"You didn't bring us. We followed you. We've survived more than ten times thanks to you, so I'd say we were due for something like this."

He spoke as though it were nothing, but he couldn't hide the tremor in his voice.

Zhang Wei licked his parched lips as he stared at the ten motionless Death Knights.

"Fight with everything you have, and make sure at least one of you survives. That's all I have to say."

A thunderous cheer answered him.

The Hunters cast off their fear, their eyes shining like morning stars.

If they had wanted safe, prosperous lives, they could have chosen another path.

But they had joined the Public Security Armed Forces Department instead of becoming bodyguards for wealthy businessmen or working as mercenaries because of their honor and sense of responsibility as Hunters.

This was a fight they could never retreat from.

“Let’s go! Sons and daughters of the people, descendants of Zhonghua[1913]!”

Zhang Wei had just finished shouting with all his strength and was about to charge the nearest Death Knight when—

Rrrrrumble!

It was almost instinctive.

The ground shook violently, and a vast, overwhelming energy washed over them. Every surviving human turned toward it, terror making their hair stand on end.

There, where all their gazes converged, a black knight slowly crossed the ruined city center.

Red eyes flashed beneath a helmet pulled low over its face. The breath of death spilled from its bloodless lips.

“Sar, Garosh.”

Words in a language of the Demon Realm that no one could understand.

Yet in the next instant, Zhang Wei realized what they meant.

Kill them all.

The ten Death Knights charged from every direction, reflected in Zhang Wei’s widened eyes.

Slash!

The slaughter began.

Splash.

A hoof stripped to bare bone stepped into a pool of blood.

The black knight gazed down at the corpse of Zhang Wei, the middle-aged Hunter who had resisted to the very end. The approaching Death Knights knelt before him on one knee.

“Lord. Your next command.”

His next command.

The black knight remained silent for a moment, then abruptly extended a hand.

Whoosh! Slash!

A black streak of light lashed out like a whip, slicing through concrete and rebar.

The building collapsed at an angle. Within the exposed interior, several humans huddled together with their hands clamped over their mouths.

[1913] *Zhonghua* is a name for China that invokes Chinese civilization and national identity.

“Jinjin. Honey. It’s okay. It’s okay…”

“Sniff… sob…”

“Dadda?”

A human male and female. And…

A creature so small and light that he could not yet tell whether it was male or female.

Was that what they called a child?

Child. Child?

Where had he heard that word before?

Pushing the sudden question aside, the black knight reached out. Every human he saw had to be annihilated. That was the command he had received.

But—

“…?”

For some reason, his hand would not move.

They were undoubtedly weak beings who would turn into a handful of blood and vanish from a mere flick of his finger, yet it was as though an invisible barrier surrounded and protected them.

“What are you?”

At the black knight’s eerie voice, the child squirming in its parents’ arms suddenly began to wail.

“This…”

The black knight abruptly raised his head and stared into the distance, then turned his mount around.

The Death Knights voiced their confusion at their leader’s sudden action.

“Lord?”

“We’re going back. Now. At once.”

“Then shall we deal with the humans—”

“We’re going back. Now. At once.”

That was all.

The ten Death Knights bowed on one knee in deference before riding after their leader.

Just before they vanished like mist, the black knight’s red gaze fell upon the three humans who had miraculously survived, then moved away.

Whoooooosh.

The blood-scented wind swept through the corpse-filled ruins.

Chapter 392

Damn it. Faster. Faster.

Whoooooosh!

I squeezed out every last ounce of strength and pushed my movement technique to its limit. The scenery blurred past as the ruined city rapidly drew closer.

But I knew how it had ended before I even arrived. No—I should say someone told me.

Beep.

SYSTEM

??? has completed its objective and disappeared.
Sudden Quest, Unexpected Assault, has been canceled.
You failed to complete the Quest. As a failure penalty, a random stat decreases by 10.
Strength decreases by 10.

The moment I heard the System notification, the tension wound tight inside me abruptly snapped.

It wasn't because I had failed the Quest or because my stat had decreased. It was because I knew what the notification meant.

The deepening silence as I approached the city—and the sight that greeted me moments later—turned my suspicion into certainty.

"…"

Blood was everywhere, and horribly mangled corpses lay strewn across the ground. Even I, after countless battles had made me accustomed to death, froze for a moment.

Slaughter.

Yes. This was slaughter. They had blown people apart, torn them to pieces, and crushed them.

The evidence that living human beings had been hunted down and killed like ants made it hard to breathe.

If even I, a complete stranger from another country, felt this way, the grief and rage of the Public Security Armed Forces Department Hunters arriving behind me were beyond words.

"Zhang Wei! Langlang!"

"W-Who the hell did this? Who the hell…? Sob…"

"No! Aaaaaah!"

These were comrades who had entrusted their backs to one another. Among the cold bodies lying before them were their siblings and lovers.

Amid the endless wailing and shouting, one person who had been standing in silence suddenly stepped forward.

Thud. Thud.

Perhaps his hollow footsteps sounded especially loud because his face, so unlike its usual self, was utterly numb and devoid of emotion.

Team Leader Choi, standing beside me, called my name quietly.

“Mr. Jin.”

“I know. Me too.”

Some things had to be done even when you wanted no part of them. This was one of those times. I forced the words past my lips.

“Shen.”

“…”

“Xiao Shen!”

Thud. Thud. Thud.

Even my forceful shout failed to stop him. Xiao Shen merely kept walking toward some unknown place, searching for the killers who had murdered his subordinates.

In the end, I had to walk up and grab him by the shoulder.

Smack.

“Stop.”

A dry, lifeless voice emerged.

“…Let go. I have to go.”

“Where?”

“Where?”

Xiao Shen looked around with empty eyes before continuing.

“I don’t know. But they must be somewhere.”

“You…”

“I have to go after them. No matter what it takes, I’ll find them and have my revenge.”

“…!”

For a moment, I couldn’t speak.

The person before me wasn’t Xiao Shen. He was me, a few years ago.

That was why I couldn’t bring myself to say what needed to be said.

Because I know how he feels.

He wanted to kill, and he probably wanted to die too.

The deaths of those close to you left behind more than rage and grief. The survivor was burdened with guilt heavier than both combined.

The guilt left behind by a hundred lives was far too much for a twenty-one-year-old to bear.

Damn it.

I swallowed the curse lingering on the tip of my tongue and tightened my grip on his shoulder.

"You're too late."

"…"

"It's already too late. We can't find them right now. That isn't a guess. I'm certain."

The System notification had told me as much. There was no possibility of a mistake.

Xiao Shen stared into my unwavering eyes and murmured blankly.

"I'm too late. I really am too late."

"I don't want to admit it either, but… yes. That's the reality."

I thought he would finally unleash all the rage and grief he had been holding back.

I thought he would wail and smash everything in sight, just as I had a few years ago.

But I was wrong. The monsters weren't the only targets of Xiao Shen's revenge.

Rattle-rattle. Thud.

The tanks were only now entering the city.

Xiao Shen watched the advancing column grow from distant specks into looming vehicles, his eyes blazing like fire.

"Then I suppose I'll have to kill that bastard, at least."

There was no question who *that bastard* meant.

General Liao. The man responsible for issuing this goddamn order.

One worthless command from him had killed a hundred Hunters and hundreds of soldiers. Even I thought he deserved to pay for it.

But…

"Fuck. I'm sorry."

Feeling wretched, I reached out.

Xiao Shen sensed something was wrong and tried to dodge, but my hand moved like flowing water and brushed his acupoints before he could escape.

Tap. Tap-tap!

The Paralysis Acupoint, the Mute Acupoint, and the Sleep Acupoint.

Xiao Shen's entire body went rigid, his voice was sealed, and a deep sleep began to overtake him.

His eyelids trembled as he fought desperately against the drowsiness pouring over him.

“For now… get some proper sleep. Their deaths weren’t your fault.”

Sshk.

At last, his eyelids closed tight. The final look in Xiao Shen’s eyes held an unmistakable question.

Why? How come?

And Xiao Shen wasn’t the only one asking it.

“Regimental Commander!”

“Jin Taekyung, you!”

Whoooooosh! Shing!

Along with furious shouts, five sounds of air being split apart rang out.

They were A-rank Hunters under Xiao Shen’s command, men called company commanders.

I swept a hand toward them as they charged without hesitation.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded outward, forcing the weapons hurtling toward me to veer away.

The company commanders barely managed to block the palm force tearing through the air, their bodies skidding backward across the ground.

It was fortunate that I had restrained my strength. If I had truly steeled myself, things would not have ended this easily.

“Everyone, calm down. I didn’t want to go this far either.”

“Kgh!”

“What the hell do you think you’re doing?!”

“How dare you lay a hand on the regimental commander…!”

“This is how you repay his kindness?!”

As the atmosphere turned hostile, Team Leader Choi stepped forward and spoke quietly.

“Mr. Jin is only repaying that kindness.”

“W-What did you say?”

“If we had left him alone, the enraged Regimental Commander Xiao would have killed General Liao.”

“…General Liao deserves to die. Even if our regimental commander hadn’t done it, we would have taken matters into our own hands.”

“I agree. But I can’t say how your country’s Central Committee would view it—especially the Crown Prince Party, to which General Liao belongs.”

“…!”

“He is the supreme commander responsible for an entire front. Killing him would not remain a personal matter.”

Team Leader Choi looked over the Public Security Armed Forces Department Hunters one by one.

They were a force nearly a thousand strong. I hadn’t thought that far ahead, but if they became entangled in an incident like this, they wouldn’t escape the consequences either.

“I won’t tell you to forget what happened today. I’m only saying that now is not the time.”

I felt the hostility begin to subside.

Team Leader Choi’s words were both practical and grounded in emotion. One of the company commanders who had not joined the attack finally spoke.

“I agree. Killing that bastard right now would be easy, but… dealing with the aftermath would not.”

“…”

“Remember this. General Liao isn’t the only reason our brothers died.”

He surveyed the horrific sea of corpses and blood, then ground his teeth.

“Let’s wait. Just a little while. Our time will come soon.”

“Haaah.”

“…Damn it all!”

Some looked to the sky and lamented. Others struggled to contain the grief and fury boiling inside them.

But it was clear that they had all reached the same unspoken agreement.

Once the situation had finally settled, Team Leader Choi let out a relieved sigh.

“That’s one less thing to worry about. I’m glad you stopped Regimental Commander Xiao, Mr. Jin.”

“…It was nothing.”

Fortunate. Was this really something we should call fortunate?

Even though I knew there had been no other choice, a bitter taste lingered in my mouth. I knew the rage and grief Xiao Shen must have felt.

“More importantly, it seemed there were survivors.”

“There was a middle-aged couple and one child. They apparently fainted from extreme tension, so they’re being moved somewhere else to rest for now.”

“Are there any other survivors?”

“We’ll find them soon enough.”

Team Leader Choi frowned and looked over my shoulder as he continued.

“Once that utterly incompetent commander gives the order, at least.”

Rattle-rattle.

The armored vehicle advancing with a deafening racket stopped about twenty meters[1914] ahead of us.

A moment later, the plump General Liao emerged under heavy guard.

“W-What in the world…?”

At the horrific sight before him, his already fair complexion turned deathly pale.

He doubled over and retched for a long while. The sight filled me with disgust, but it also made me think that perhaps he was human after all.

You bastard. I guess you do feel guilty.

Everyone there had probably thought the same thing.

But General Liao’s next words reminded me of something I had forgotten.

People like him always managed to exceed the limits of imagination.

“N-No. The operation wasn’t supposed to fail!”

“…!”

The world seemed to slow down.

As though in slow motion, I saw shock and fury spread across the faces around me.

I saw Team Leader Choi reach for me and heard his urgent shout.

“Mr. Jin!”

But it was already too late.

By the time he called my name, I had crossed the twenty-odd meters[1915] between us and appeared before General Liao.

An operation. An operation…

I couldn’t suppress the incredulous laugh that escaped me.

I reached toward the man staring up at me as though he had seen a ghost.

Crack! Crunch!

It was over in an instant.

With pure physical strength, without putting so much as a thread of internal energy behind it, I broke both his arms and crushed his kneecaps.

Be grateful I still have one shred of reason left.

His jaw dropped. His eyes bulged.

Then he screamed like a pig being slaughtered.

“Aaaaaaaaargh!!!”

I spat at him as he rolled his eyes back, collapsed to the ground, and convulsed in pain, then turned away.

I didn’t forget to address the staff officer staring at me as though his soul had left his body.

[1914] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

[1915] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

“Report me to your superiors if you’ve got a fucking problem, you bastards.”

Shaking his head, Team Leader Choi approached with a high-grade potion.

The chair was enormous and grotesque.

That was only natural. It had been fashioned from human and monster bones.

Yet it was neither as grotesque nor as terrifying as its owner.

Tap. Tap-tap.

A fleshless finger tapped the skull decorating the armrest.

The figure was well over three meters[1916] tall, with a massive frame. The black robe draped over it rippled like mist.

It resembled a king seated upon a throne, and that description was not far from the truth.

The Arch Lich.

It was a being worthy of being called the lord of the undead—a king who ruled over death.

But the Arch Lich itself did not think so. There was another who was the true king, while it was merely that king’s loyal servant.

But…

Was it still too soon?

The Arch Lich felt a sudden pang of regret.

It possessed truly formidable magical power, but it was still far weaker than the strength it had once possessed. On top of that, the situation on the battlefield was proving more difficult than expected.

After silently sinking into thought, the Arch Lich opened its mouth.

“Are you listening, my servant?”

The being prostrated in the darkness answered.

“Yes, my lord.”

“Pull back the front line. We’ll draw the human army in.”

“I obey.”

“Go. Carry my command to every legion within the reach of my power.”

The black knight rose and slowly withdrew.

At the final moment, the Arch Lich’s chair was reflected in his eyes, which burned red.

Tap. Tap-tap.

The skull decorating its armrest was far too small to have belonged to an adult.

[1916] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

Chapter 393

War is a succession of battles.

When a battle that has left countless deaths and rivers of blood finally ends, victory and defeat are decided. The survivors gather in one place and prepare for tomorrow's battle.

That was why the commanders of the eastern and western fronts in Sichuan Province had gathered together.

"The casualties are too high."

The first to break the silence was a middle-aged soldier who looked to be in his forties. His uniform caked with dried blood, he continued in a weary voice.

"We barely managed to hold the high ground, but we lost more than three thousand troops today alone."

A victory that had left nothing but wounds.

Three thousand troops was an enormous loss in itself, but the greater problem was that Hunters accounted for more than thirty percent of the dead, including the commander and several high-ranking officers.

Even considering the threefold disparity in troop strength, the blow was devastating.

"Has headquarters sent a reply?"

"Yes. They held an internal meeting and said they'd dispatch a new commander before dawn."

"That's a relief, at least. Then do you happen to know who the new commander will be…?"

As they spoke amid the somber atmosphere, someone abruptly cut in.

"A relief? Do you all really think so?"

"…!"

The words of someone who had remained silent carried weight. Even more so when that person was a living hero of the Great Cataclysm and an S-rank Hunter.

"Half the command staff, including the commander, were torn apart by flying monsters. The troops under them panicked, driving the casualties even higher. Can you really call any part of that a relief?"

The people flinched beneath the gaze filled with an irresistible aura.

"W-Well, the thing is…"

"The fact that you're trying to make excuses means you know I'm right. But…"

A chilling voice slipped between red lips.

Faye Chen's gaze swept across the room, then stopped abruptly on one man.

"Why don't you have any excuses?"

After a brief silence, Wu Heixing swirled the liquor in his crystal glass.

“Why should I?”

“Why? Well…”

Faye Chen’s eyes darkened.

“Maybe because some fucking idiot abandoned his assigned position, giving the flying monsters waiting for that exact moment the chance to tear command headquarters apart?”

“…I went to support the front line.”

Wu Heixing’s answer was nothing more than a pathetic excuse. When he abandoned the rear, the troops on the front line under Faye Chen’s command had been successfully holding back the endless assault of the monster army.

“Oh, right. There was that, too. You charged deep into enemy territory like some clueless brat because you wanted all the glory, and the formation collapsed. Those kids who went after you to save your ass—did you even know they never found their bodies?”

“People live and die on the battlefield all the time.”

“Of course. It happens all the time.”

Faye Chen continued quietly.

“People like you dying without anyone knowing used to be even more common. Come to think of it, the world has gotten pretty nice. If this had been during the Great Cataclysm…”

But Faye Chen never got to finish.

Crack! Crash!

A sharp crack rang out as crystal shards flew in every direction.

Having crushed the glass in his hand, Wu Heixing slowly rose to his feet.

“That’s enough.”

“Enough? You’re getting awfully informal with me.”

“There’s a limit to how much I’ll tolerate, Faye Chen.”

“Go on, then. Keep talking. Just remember—the more casual your tone gets, the shorter your lifespan becomes.”

“How dare some Hong Konger who’s practically a traitor—!”

“Ah. If you mean the Hong Konger who cleaned up the front line you shat all over, then yes, I suppose that’s me.”

Whoooooosh.

The tremendous auras pouring from the two of them engulfed the room. The pressure was so overwhelming that the others could barely breathe.

Then, in the next instant, the brief standoff between the two S-rank Hunters ended as a mocking smile touched Faye Chen’s lips.

“You’re scared and exhausted, but you still want the glory. That’s why you’re growing more desperate by the day, isn’t it?”

"What?"

"Kid, that's what war does. It drives people to the brink and tests them. You need a strong mind to endure a hell like this. Of course it's hard for a spoiled child like you who's always done whatever he pleased."

"…!"

Wu Heixing's face twisted grotesquely. Every word out of Faye Chen's mouth had struck home.

"An S-rank Hunter? So what? Mentally, you're nothing but a seven-year-old child. In a war like this, we'd be better off without someone like you."

"Shut up! What the hell do you know…?"

"What do I know? You're asking me that?"

Faye Chen's derisive snort made Wu Heixing's face flush bright red.

He had been born with wealth and power in both hands, but his opponent was a war hero who had fought her way through the Great Cataclysm.

The media discriminated against Faye Chen for being from Hong Kong, but when it came to experience, she was someone Wu Heixing could never hope to match.

"Why aren't you answering?"

Wu Heixing clenched his teeth, refusing to respond, and swept his gaze around the room.

No one had bothered to say anything aloud, but the looks in their eyes resembled Faye Chen's.

These fucking bastards…!

Even more infuriating was that some of them belonged to the Crown Prince Party and had close ties to Wu Heixing.

The Crown Prince Party was the largest faction within the Chinese Communist Party. As a blood descendant of one of its most prominent leaders, Wu Heixing felt betrayed to the bone.

"I'll remember what happened today. Every last bit of it."

Leaving those furious words behind, Wu Heixing turned away.

As he departed reeking of liquor, Faye Chen's quiet voice flew after him and struck him squarely in the back.

"Remember this, too. Today is the last day I'll tolerate a child's reckless bravado. If this happens again… I won't forgive you."

Grind.

Wu Heixing returned to his quarters grinding his teeth. The first thing he did was smash everything in sight.

Boom! Boom-boom-boom!

"Fucking Hong Kong bitch! Fucking traitorous bastards!"

The expensive luxury furnishings he had brought over on his private jet despite the chaos shattered into pieces.

He spent a long while stomping and smashing everything within reach, screaming like a madman. At last, breathing heavily, Wu Heixing threw himself onto the bed.

“Damn it.”

His anger refused to subside.

Far from fading, it burned hotter the more he thought about it. His heart pounded so violently that his vision nearly went white.

How dare they treat me like this?

He had been born into the family of one of the most powerful men in China and had risen all the way to this point.

Once he became an S-rank Hunter, the world had belonged to him.

No matter what major disaster he caused, the worst that happened was being summoned by his father and scolded a few times. He had never cared about the criticism from the public or opposing factions.

I’m Wu Heixing. Wu Heixing!

An S-rank Hunter was the face of a nation, another name for its national power. No matter how harshly public opinion condemned him, that fact remained unchanged.

That was reality.

Was that why he had become more passionate about media interviews and parties than smelly, dirty raids? Why he had stopped training and started using drugs?

But the first war of his life was chaos. Watching the monster armies surge forward without end, day after day, left him struggling to breathe.

For someone who had followed an elite path paved with diamonds, it was an unbearably harsh environment.

On top of that, one person’s influence lingered behind Wu Heixing’s repeated mistakes.

Jin Taekyung.

The second wall he had encountered in his life—and one far greater than Lei Fei, the object of his long-standing jealousy.

The shadow Jin Taekyung cast was vast and dark.

The fear carved deep into Wu Heixing’s mind by that one-sided defeat would never leave him as long as Jin Taekyung remained.

Right. As long as that peninsula bangzi[1917] doesn’t disappear…

An inscrutable light flashed in Wu Heixing’s eyes as he stared at the ceiling.

[1917] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans.

He smiled, recalling the conversation he had shared with Lee Jungryong on the night of his crushing defeat. His boiling anger had already vanished without a trace.

Just wait and see. We'll find out who gets the last laugh.

Once his mind calmed, the fatigue he had temporarily forgotten came rushing back and weighed down his eyelids. As drowsiness overcame him, Wu Heixing suddenly thought:

Damn it. How many more battles like today's are we going to have to fight?

A short while later, Wu Heixing fell fast asleep, unaware that countless monster armies were withdrawing from the front lines under cover of the pitch-dark night.

The mass withdrawal was taking place simultaneously across every front in Sichuan Province.

"…Phew."

Xiao Shen let out a sigh, his eyes red and bloodshot.

He had spent the night with his Sleep Acupoint struck and had only regained consciousness two hours ago.

The moment he opened his eyes, he had gone berserk, shouting that he was going to kill General Liao. Team Leader Choi and I had sweated bullets trying to calm him down.

"Xiao Shen, are you all right?"

"Yeah. Have you calmed down a little?"

Xiao Shen answered.

"Yes. I couldn't put any strength into my body when I first woke up, but I'm fine now. I've got more than enough strength to rip that bastard's head off."

"…"

"…"

Calm, my ass.

Still, despite what he said, only his fists were trembling. It didn't look like he planned to play golf with General Liao's head right this second, so I breathed a little easier.

"I'll say it again. I didn't want to do that to you. The timing was just bad."

Xiao Shen was silent for a moment before nodding.

"I know, hyung.[1918] I also know you stepped in for me."

"When did you hear about that?"

[1918] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man to whom he is close.

“The company commanders came and told me. They said you flew into a rage and broke General Liao’s arms and legs.”

“…It wasn’t exactly something I should’ve done after stopping you. But, well, that’s how it turned out.”

Team Leader Choi cut in stiffly.

“If you knew you shouldn’t do it, why did you?”

“Well, uh… I lost my head for a moment.”

“We’re fortunate the current situation is so chaotic. Otherwise, this could have become a serious problem.”

“Lucky for us, then. If things weren’t like this, that bastard would’ve died by my hand already.”

An incompetent commander was more frightening than an enemy.

General Liao had thrown away nearly a thousand lives, then started whining about a failed operation and military glory. He deserved to die.

“It all worked out. His injuries are almost healed thanks to the potion, and they have plenty of reasons to feel guilty themselves, so they’ll quietly let it slide.”

“Grudges last a long time, Mr. Jin. He’s a high-ranking general in the Central Military Commission and a blue-blooded scion of the Crown Prince Party, notorious for holding grudges. There’s every chance this will cause trouble later.”

“What can we do? The water’s already spilled. We’ll deal with it if trouble comes.”

Team Leader Choi was shaking his head in disbelief at my nonchalant answer when Xiao Shen spoke in a low voice.

“Don’t worry. What you’re concerned about, Mr. Choi, won’t happen.”

“Hm?”

“Xiao Shen, have you heard something?”

“Not so much heard…”

After a moment’s hesitation, Xiao Shen shook his head, his expression stiff.

“Um… it’s merely my personal opinion.”

“…?”

“…?”

What was that suspicious smell?

Team Leader Choi and I were staring at Xiao Shen doubtfully when—

“M-M-M-May I come in?”

“Did an earthquake hit your vocal cords? Come in.”

Only then did the person who had been pacing outside the tent cautiously step inside.

It was a familiar face—one of General Liao’s closest staff officers.

He was also the man who had pissed himself the day before when he saw me break his superior’s limbs.

“Well, if it isn’t the great nation’s little pants-pisser. What brings you here?”

“G-G-G…”

“S-S-S-Spit it out already. What are you trying to say? Please, just speak properly.”

The staff officer flinched, swallowed hard, and answered.

“A-A guest has arrived.”

“A guest?”

“Yes.”

“Who? Are visitors even allowed here?”

It can’t be Mom and Hayeon, can it?

That absurd thought had just crossed my mind when the staff officer’s answer came flying at me.

“Magic Johnson, a Hunter from the United States, has come to see you.”

I could feel Team Leader Choi clench his butt beside me.

Chapter 394

As expected, the mainland was on an entirely different scale.

I'd been told this was a small city, but its size and population far exceeded anything I had imagined once we entered it.

That also meant quite a few buildings had survived the monster army's rampage intact.

This one included.

At the entrance to the municipal hospital, which was currently serving as a temporary headquarters, a tall white Hunter spotted Team Leader Choi and me and approached.

"I've been waiting for you."

"Did Magic Johnson send you…?"

"Yes. My name is Michael Johnson. Feel free to call me Michael."

"Ah, sure."

Is everyone over there named Johnson? Is there some kind of Johnson family reunion in L.A.?

Still wondering, I shook Michael's hand.

He beamed at me.

"What?"

"I'm a huge fan of yours. Lord Fuck."

"…I'd appreciate it if you called me Jin instead of Lord Fuck."

"Why? I'd love a nickname like that."

"Then should I call you Little Johnson?"

Michael's face turned dead serious.

"Nope."

Look how firm he is.

I stared at him in disbelief.

"It's the same principle. So please call me Jin."

"Ah, okay."

That Lord Fuck nickname is really spreading to every corner of the globe.

Cheon Taemin had defeated the Demon King, been hailed as the savior of the twenty-first century, and earned the incredibly badass title Slayer. Even if I killed a Demon God instead of a Demon King, I'd probably still be Lord Fuck.

At best, I might evolve into Lord Fuuuck.

"Don't take it too hard. Lord Fuck has a certain warmth and charm to it, don't you think?"

"Team Leader, are you making fun of me?"

"Of course not."

Team Leader Choi let out a quiet laugh, and Michael called out to him.

"Choi. You came too."

"You know me?"

"Of course. Word of how much Johnson likes you has already spread throughout the Guild."

"…"

I jabbed Team Leader Choi in the ribs as his expression darkened.

"Don't take it too hard. Johnson's Johnson likes you, Team Leader."

"…Mr. Jin. You just said Johnson twice."

"Did I? Must've slipped out."

Pretending not to notice Team Leader Choi's sharp glare, I asked Michael, "Where's Johnson?"

"Ah, I'll show you."

We followed him inside. The moment we entered the lobby, the murmuring abruptly died away, and every eye in the room swung toward us.

I'd heard that a few civilians rescued during the night were here, but since this was a temporary headquarters, the place seemed to be filled almost entirely with soldiers.

"The whole atmosphere changes when Jin shows up."

"I was already famous, but I'm probably a little more famous after yesterday."

"Oh, did you kill a Named Monster or something?"

I shrugged at Michael's question.

"Something like that."

Considering General Liao's position within the military, he was a Named Monster in his own right.

His side had issued a gag order, but somehow the rumor had spread everywhere. Everywhere I went, I could hear soldiers whispering under their breath.

"Did you hear? Yesterday, Mr. Jin did something to the commander…"

"I heard the story, but wasn't it just a rumor?"

"They say it's true. The Hunters confirmed it, and apparently so did one of the headquarters operations staff. Rao Yang heard the whole thing loud and clear."

"Huh. If that's true, I'm disappointed in Mr. Jin."

"Me too. I thought he was a hero of the people."

The reaction was exactly what I'd expected.

Birds of a feather flock together, and people always side with their own.

Naturally, the soldiers wouldn't be too happy about me mauling their direct superior…

“He shouldn’t have stopped at breaking the man’s limbs. He should’ve ripped his head off.”

“Exactly. How many people died because of that pig bastard?”

“I heard he took a huge cut from the latest defense procurement scandal too. That’s why he’s keeping quiet and letting this slide even after getting his arms and legs broken. Following Mr. Jin around is the only way he can pick up a few scraps of military glory and save his own skin.”

“That thieving son of a bitch. A bastard like him should be hanged in Tiananmen Square.”

…What? They seem to like me quite a lot.

It wasn’t just the enlisted soldiers. Even the officers were whispering among themselves.

They called General Liao an incompetent pig who had sacrificed his troops. Some said they finally understood why they were still using canteens manufactured during the Chinese Civil War.

Combined with General Liao’s existing reputation, everything that had recently come to light opened the floodgates. Remarks that could have gotten them arrested for insulting a superior poured out one after another.

“The mood is favorable. At this rate, we shouldn’t have to worry about the consequences.”

Team Leader Choi spoke as he walked beside me. Still dazed, I answered, “Yeah. If I’d known, I would’ve hit him a few more times.”

“Hmm. I do still have a few high-grade potions left.”

“Look at you, Team Leader. You’re getting good at jokes.”

“I wouldn’t say I was entirely joking.”

“Huh?”

What’s gotten into this guy all of a sudden?

Team Leader Choi stared straight at me as I struggled to process his unexpected response.

“Mr. Jin, you are indisputably an S-rank Hunter. You’re the dream and symbol of ordinary citizens, as well as a celebrity with enormous public support. General Liao, on the other hand, is the embodiment of the corrupt establishment. Anyone who tries to come after you will have to be prepared to pay an enormous price.”

“So you’re saying it wouldn’t matter if I hit him a little harder?”

“There would still be consequences, but someone like General Liao, who is already on the verge of ruin, won’t be able to drag you down with him.”

“Seriously? Just a few hours ago, you were telling me not to cause trouble.”

“Even the best sports car will crash if all you do is step on the accelerator. You need someone beside you to hit the brakes, like me. And…”

Team Leader Choi continued in a low voice.

"Sometimes you also need to maintain the track so the sports car can run properly. Like now."

"…?"

"Too many people witnessed what happened yesterday. If the gag order was bound to fail anyway, I thought it would be better to spread the story as quickly as possible."

It didn't take long for the question mark in my head to turn into an exclamation point.

"Team Leader, did you…?"

Team Leader Choi smiled at my slack-jawed expression.

"Getting ahead of the story and spreading the version most favorable to us. It's a method Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong often uses."

"…Huh."

Now everything fit together.

I'd wondered how the rumor had spread so quickly that the gag order was already meaningless. Team Leader Choi had clearly laid the groundwork in advance.

The Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department already despised General Liao, so getting them to cooperate must have been easy. As for the soldiers…

He paid them.

In the end, it always came down to money. Team Leader Choi had paid people to talk, and they had spread the rumor in whatever way was most favorable to us.

Besides, wasn't the military a place crawling with microphones and loudspeakers?

Rumors spread fast.

Ten people opened their mouths, a hundred people heard them, and those hundred passed the story on to a thousand more. Add a generous sprinkling of MSG along the way, and before long the inflated rumor became accepted as fact.

But he thought of all that and pulled it off overnight?

I gazed at Team Leader Choi with newfound respect.

"Team Leader Choi, are you Zhuge Kongming? Zhang Liang?"[1919]

"This was nothing special."

"Team Leader Come, I think I'm about to Choi."

"…Stop it."

While we talked, Michael, who had been walking ahead of us, came to a stop.

Knock, knock.

"Johnson. It's Michael."

[1919] Zhuge Kongming was the Zhuge Clan's famous ancestor, and Zhang Liang was Liu Bang's strategist; both were renowned for their counsel.

Two auras, one large and one small, stirred beyond the door marked VIP Private Room. Then a deep, cheerful voice called from inside.

"Oh, come on in."

"You heard him. My job ends here, so I'll be going."

Michael shrugged at us and stepped aside.

Team Leader Choi's butt had already clenched tight, so I opened the sliding door for him.

Rattle.

Two people came into view.

"Haha! So we meet again, charming young men!"

The first was a huge Black man who strode toward us and extended a hand as large as a pot lid—Magic Johnson.

And then…

"Eek!"

A plump pig recoiled in horror the moment he saw me.

I glanced at General Liao, whose double chin was quivering, then took Magic Johnson's hand and whispered, "When did you get here?"

"About… thirty minutes ago?"

"What about the southern front you're in charge of? And why didn't you come find us right away? Why are you sitting around with this guy?"

"Hold on. I'll answer your questions one at a time. But first, I need to say hello to Choi."

Snatch.

Like a hawk swooping down on its prey, Magic Johnson seized Team Leader Choi's hand and greeted him warmly.

"How have you been? Did you think about me a lot?"

"…Yes."

Team Leader Choi's answer was one hundred percent sincere. He must have thought about all kinds of things on the way here.

But since Magic Johnson had no idea what the answer meant, it was more than enough to set his heart aflutter.

"Oh! Then you're just like me. We have so much in common, don't we?"

"…"

We're probably very different when it comes to which gender we like.

"Anyway, it's good to see you again."

His gaze dripping with lingering affection, Magic Johnson finally ended his reunion with Team Leader Choi and answered my earlier question.

"And Jin, if you're worried about the southern front I'm in charge of, don't be. Nothing will go wrong just because I stepped away for a little while."

"It sounds like the war is going quite well."

"Hmm. I'm not sure about that. Still, it is encouraging that the monster armies are retreating from every front."

"Oh, the monster armies are retreating… What?"

Team Leader Choi and I turned to each other and blinked as though we'd rehearsed it.

What the hell was he talking about?

Team Leader Choi recovered before I did and asked Magic Johnson, "This is the first we've heard of it. Mr. Johnson, could you tell us what happened?"

"It's exactly as I said. The monster armies turned tail during the night. When we looked into it, the same thing had happened on every front."

"But we didn't detect any movement on our side."

"Ah, let me correct myself. The western front is the exception."

"Why is that?"

"What? Hahaha!"

Magic Johnson let out a booming laugh and clapped me on the shoulder.

"Because this western front has penetrated deeper into enemy territory than any other. I don't know what kind of scheme the Arch Lich is plotting, but the western front is already an open highway. The monsters here have already retreated as far as they can."

"Oh."

I'd momentarily forgotten.

Unlike the other fronts, which were advancing little by little under Army and Air Force cover, I had simply killed and smashed everything in my path as I pushed forward.

I did tear through them with unstoppable momentum, but did we really get that far?

Magic Johnson laughed loudly at my bewildered expression.

"That doesn't sound like the Genghis Khan of the twenty-first century. You've accomplished an incredible military feat. Why not smile a little?"

"It's far too early to relax and smile. But never mind the monster armies pulling back. Why are you here?"

"I came to see Choi."

"…!"

"…!"

"I'm kidding."

Look how pale Team Leader Choi's gotten. One more joke and his sphincter might rupture.

"I'm taking some personnel away temporarily, so I had to deliver the written orders to the commander."

“You’re taking people away? Where?”
“Chengdu. A military conference has been convened.”

Chapter 395

"Follow me."

Magic Johnson led us to none other than the hospital rooftop.

After sweeping my eyes across the empty landing pad, where there wasn't a helicopter or jet in sight, I asked,

"There's nothing here."

"Nope. I'm here."

Magic Johnson's answer was short and simple, but what it implied was anything but.

Team Leader Choi's eyes widened slightly. He seemed to have reached the same conclusion I had.

"Mr. Johnson. You don't mean…"

"That's right. We're going to travel by teleportation magic."

Teleportation. In other words, instant travel.

Magic Johnson spoke as casually as if he were suggesting a ride on a tricycle, but everyone knew teleportation magic was infamous for its extreme difficulty.

The finicky conditions required to cast it were one thing. If the coordinates were even slightly off, you could easily wind up dead.

A single misstep could mean ending up fused with an apple tree or a boulder. Horrifying.

"Can't we just take a jet?"

"Nope."

Magic Johnson answered firmly and narrowed his eyes.

"Hey, Jin. You don't actually distrust me, do you? I'm Magic Johnson. Do I have to show you before you'll believe me?"

"…"

You saying that somehow makes it sound even stranger.

Whether he intended to show me teleportation magic or his Johnson, I didn't care. I just wanted to travel peacefully by jet.

Team Leader Choi noticed my pleading expression and spoke up.

"Mr. Johnson, as you know, this area is within the Arch Lich's sphere of influence. Magic is being disrupted, and even communications are unreliable."

"Ah, so that's what this is about. I thought it was something else."

Magic Johnson let out a quiet laugh.

"How do you think I got here?"

"Huh?"

"Don't tell me…"

"That's right. I teleported. There was a little interference, but it wasn't enough to hold Magic Johnson back."

Snap!

Magic Johnson snapped his fingers, and a pillar of flame erupted from thin air. He cast the spell as naturally as breathing—a striking contrast to the mages of the Public Security Armed Forces Department, who had been unable to use magic properly because of the interference.

"You could do that from the beginning?"

"Of course not. Until now, I could still manage most ordinary spells despite the interference, but teleportation is too dangerous. I didn't even dare attempt it."

"Then…"

"The Arch Lich. His power had been gradually weakening. In particular, a considerable portion of the interference disappeared after last night. Though communications still seem to be a complete mess."

It was something he could say—and pull off—only because he was one of just three archmages in the entire world.

Magic Johnson flashed his white teeth and held out a hand to us.

"That should be enough to earn your trust, don't you think?"

"Well, if you put it that way."

I took his hand without much hesitation, but Team Leader Choi quietly stepped back.

"Team Leader Choi?"

"I'll stay here."

"Why, Choi?"

"There are still matters I need to handle. Besides, given how little influence I have in the discussion, attending in person or hearing about it afterward will make little difference."

Team Leader Choi always assessed the situation coolly. If he couldn't change the course of events himself, he pulled lower-priority work forward and dealt with that instead.

I wanted to tell him that he was mistaken, but I quietly nodded.

He wasn't wrong.

Even the S-rank Hunters whose opinions carried weight were ultimately mercenaries from other countries—borrowed blades.

That was why Chairman Xiao Yang and Minister Wei Fenghu had made it clear that overall command remained in their hands.

"Choi's dropping out? This can't be happening! Jin has no Charm!"

"…"

I really want to drive a nail through him. Then again, maybe this is for the best.

After whining for quite some time, Magic Johnson said goodbye to Team Leader Choi with a deeply disappointed expression.

“Can’t be helped. See you next time, Choi.”

“Take care.”

“Take care of what? It’ll be over in an instant.”

Magic Johnson shrugged and turned to me.

“Hey, Jin. Ready?”

“Yes.”

“Hold my hand tight. Don’t let go.”

“…Why are we interlocking fingers? Can’t I just hold your palm?”

Isn’t this the sort of thing couples do?

As a guy in his late twenties who had been single his entire life, I couldn’t help feeling uncomfortable about interlocking fingers with a huge Black man.

Magic Johnson spoke gently when he saw my reluctance.

“You can let go if you want. But if you lose your grip during the journey, you might die.”

Thinking of my first love from childhood, I clutched Magic Johnson’s hand tightly.

“Let’s go, darling.”

Magic Johnson’s expression turned stern.

“Sorry, but Jin isn’t my type. You don’t have to squeeze that hard, so could you ease up?”

“…Oh. Right.”

“Then, here we go.”

Just as I opened my mouth to answer—

Whoooooosh!

Gasp!

My breath caught, and the taut air constricted around my entire body.

Through my blurring vision, Team Leader Choi wavered like a mirage before vanishing.

The earth and sky flipped upside down.

Then, at last, came an overwhelming sense of release.

“Hah!”

I expelled the breath I had been holding and inhaled deeply. Cool air filled my lungs. I blinked, and my briefly clouded vision cleared.

It felt as if barely a second had passed, yet an entirely different landscape and different people stood around me.

“Our final guest has arrived.”

Wei Fenghu, Minister of National Defense under China's Central Military Commission, approached and patted me on the shoulder. He looked as though he had aged ten years in the past week.

"Everyone is waiting. Let us go inside together."

"W-wait a second."

"Yes?"

"Don't come any closer…"

"Uweeeeeegh!"

Splash!

For the record, I'm fairly tall. About two heads taller than Wei Fenghu.

As I emptied my stomach over the thinning crown of the old general's head, Magic Johnson's voice reached me.

"Ah, I forgot to mention that the motion sickness gets worse. I'm sorry, Jin. I'm sorry, Wei Fenghu."

"You should've told me that sooner—uweeeeeegh!"

"…Hah."

It took a little longer before I was able to attend the meeting.

A holographic recording played in the darkness of a vast conference room.

The footage showed exactly what one person had seen: a complicated control panel, clouds scattering beyond reinforced glass, and tiny specks appearing far below as the aircraft descended.

The things covering the ground surged forward like waves, with no ranks or formation.

Monsters.

It wasn't difficult to tell that the footage came from a fighter pilot's perspective. Wearing a head-mounted camera, the pilot radioed someone.

"This is YANU-4885. I repeat, YANU-4885. Target confirmed. Locked on."

"You are cleared to fire."

Crackle. Crackle.

The transmission was riddled with static, but the words were clear enough. The pilot took a deep breath and carried out the mission without hesitation.

Rumble.

The fighter trembled slightly as one of its missiles launched. It dwindled into a speck as it streaked toward the center of the advancing monster army—

Whoosh!

A black vortex abruptly appeared in the empty air above the monsters and swallowed the missile.

“Hngh!”

The pilot gasped and hurriedly pressed a red button on the control panel.

But then—

Boom! Crackle.

The footage cut out amid a thunderous roar that suddenly crashed through the room.

The hologram disappeared, and Minister Wei Fenghu spoke with a grave expression.

“What do the rest of you make of it?”

Magic Johnson lit a cigar before answering.

“Teleportation magic. The missile was transported above the fighter.”

“Mr. Johnson, could you do the same?”

After a moment of thought, Magic Johnson answered.

“It wouldn’t be difficult. But I’m not confident I could do it that quickly or accurately.”

“Even for an archmage such as yourself?”

“…Hmm.”

Magic Johnson gave a slight nod and exhaled cigar smoke.

He, too, was an S-rank Hunter who had accomplished feats that would go down in history. He must have been proud of his abilities, so he couldn’t have been pleased to learn that he had been outdone by a monster called the Arch Lich.

But this meeting wasn’t about protecting anyone’s pride.

We had to face reality.

“Then we can’t count on fire support. If we launch anything too powerful and it gets redirected, the result could be catastrophic.”

Faye Chen continued, lightly touching her wineglass with one slender finger.

“I expected as much, but now that it’s come to this, we have no choice but to settle the matter on the ground.”

“If matters continue as they are, the tide of battle will gradually improve. The royal guard of the British Empire, led by this prince, has crushed the monster army. More importantly, that wine you are drinking—is it perhaps a 1945 Romanée-Conti?”

“No.”

“Hm. You don’t know how to drink.”

Faye Chen glared at Prince Felix.

“Oh, my. What is this child talking about? Get a grip. The British Empire was dissolved long ago, and the monsters didn’t retreat because you won a few battles. They retreated because of that fellow sitting across from you.”

Prince Felix glanced at me.

“I heard that you distinguished yourself greatly on the Western Front…but are all those stories truly accurate?”

What, does he think I’m lying?

I stared at Prince Felix incredulously.

“Then they’re true, aren’t they? What, you think I made it all up? If you don’t want to believe me, don’t.”

“Your great achievements may be worthy of praise, but your words and conduct are remarkably insolent. You will refer to me as His Highness and always speak respectfully.”

I readily complied with his demand.

“His Highness, did you eat your fish and chips wrong?”

“Hmm. A man of matchless courage, yet utterly lacking in manners.”

“…”

Utterly lacking in manners, my ass. Maybe I should make sure he’s lacking one ball, too.

For the record, the guy I’d beaten up about a week ago kept his mouth firmly shut and wouldn’t even meet my eyes.

It’s nice that he’s quiet, but something about it feels off.

Given Wu Heixing’s stupidity, I’d expected him to come at me at least a few more times. Either he was more cowardly than I’d thought, or I had misjudged him.

More importantly, someone else in the room bothered me far more than Wu Heixing did.

“You’ve been awfully quiet. Don’t you have anything to say?”

Lee Jungryong—the snake coiled in wait—smiled gently.

“Thank you for your concern, but I’m fine. A mercenary’s virtue is following the employer’s wishes without comment.”

“Oh, is that so?”

“It’s a simple principle.”

I smiled back.

“But for someone who says that, your performance has been a little lackluster. Things on the northern front don’t seem to be going very well. Was that your employer’s wish too?”

“…!”

At my words, silence descended over the room as if everyone had been doused with cold water.

As every gaze turned toward him, Lee Jungryong stroked his chin.

“I find that remark unpleasant. Ares Guild and I did our best.”

“Your best? Really?”

“We fought ten battles over the past week and won nine of them. Although we unfortunately suffered one defeat, I would call that an impressive military record.”

Ten battles, nine wins, one loss. By the numbers, it was certainly an impressive record.

But two days ago, when Team Leader Choi and I heard about the defeat on the northern front, we had both let out hollow laughs.

What a sly old man.

Lee Jungryong was one of the strongest men in the world—or, even by Murim standards, an incredibly powerful martial artist.

Given his personality, there was no chance he had revealed the full extent of his abilities. He had to be even stronger than the public believed.

And someone like that had the nerve to say—

Unfortunately suffered one defeat, my ass.

I couldn’t speak for anyone else, but I was certain.

If Lee Jungryong had taken the field and still lost, then the defeat had been intentional from beginning to end.

The members of Ares Guild had withdrawn intact despite the staggering casualties around them. They were living proof.

Though since I can’t prove anything, I suppose it’s still only a suspicion.

That was also why Lee Jungryong could remain so relaxed. He loosely crossed his arms.

“I regret the defeat that day, but I would appreciate it if you refrained from making hasty accusations. There was a clear reason for our loss.”

“A clear reason?”

“Who could have expected a Death Knight to appear under those circumstances? Once the commander died, the ensuing confusion became impossible to control.”

“If you mean the Death Knights…”

“I heard they appeared on the Western Front last night as well. Is that not so?”

His words brought something to mind.

The testimony of the civilian couple rescued from the small city.

Ten Death Knights had slaughtered nearly a thousand troops, while their leader, the Black Knight, had left without killing the couple for some unknown reason.

That Black Knight had bothered me ever since I heard their story.

“Then among the ones that appeared on the northern front, was there perhaps—”

My question to Lee Jungryong never reached its end.

Urgent footsteps raced down the corridor, and someone who looked like a Chinese officer burst through the door.

Bang!

“Huff, huff. Emergency! Emergency!”

He continued while gasping for breath.

“We have received word that the monster army has advanced! Fighting has broken out on every front!”

“…What?”

Chapter 396

The Black Knight raised his head and looked up at the sky.

A clear blue expanse without a single cloud. But to the Black Knight's eyes, which had long since lost their light, it appeared only as a dark, murky gray.

How dark.

The thought left him feeling strangely unsettled. Dark? What did darkness even mean?

He had always been the Black Knight. A being born from darkness could not understand what darkness was.

But this… What is it?

Light and sunlight. A child laughing brightly. Someone's hand stroking his head…

Several words and inexplicable scenes flashed through his mind in succession, leaving him confused.

If not for the call from one of his subordinates a moment later, the Black Knight would have stood there for a long time.

"Lord."

"Please."

Black armor as dark as night covered his entire body. Green lights flickered between the slits of the helmet covering his head.

Two Death Knights dismounted from their skeletal warhorses and knelt on one knee. They continued in flat, emotionless voices.

"Give us—"

"your orders."

Ah.

The Black Knight recalled something he had briefly forgotten: the command given by the lord he served.

"Go. Advance in all directions, trample everything, and kill them all. Offer me mountains of corpses and seas of blood."

His lord's commands were absolute. With even his soul bound to that lord, the Black Knight faithfully obeyed.

He had appointed the ten Death Knights under his command to lead five legions, then personally taken the vanguard of one legion and come here.

But why this place, of all places?

The Black Knight gazed at the small city in the distance.

It was a place he remembered. The place where the unfamiliar word *child* had suddenly come to mind, and where he had sensed an enormous power whose nature he could not identify.

But the Black Knight had no idea why he had come here.

“Lord?”

“Lord?”

After silently looking down at his subordinates, the Black Knight finally gave his command.

“Advance.”

“Your command.”

“We obey.”

Having received the answer they had been waiting for, the Death Knights mounted their skeletal warhorses and raised their enormous spears high.

Pitch-black demonic qi surged from the spearheads, and the monsters packed across the broad plain let out shrill howls.

—Kik. Kikikikik.

—Graaaargh!

There were Skeletons that had died so recently that flesh still clung to their bones, small monsters such as goblins and Orcs, and large monsters such as Trolls and ogres.

By a rough estimate, they numbered in the tens of thousands. Overhead, flocks of Gargoyles and Wyverns cast enormous shadows across the land.

“Rally.”

“Do it.”

At the next command, roughly two hundred Dullahans formed ranks. Holding their severed heads in one hand and weapons in the other, they sat astride beasts made of white bone, their eyes gleaming with a vicious light.

“Prepare.”

“for the charge.”

The two Death Knights took position at the tip of the legion. Their spearheads, raised as if to pierce the sky, slowly descended to point toward the city.

A city of humans. But soon, it would become a city of the undead—a land of death.

“Public Security Armed Forces Department, assemble!”

“F-fuck! Monsters! They’re here!”

“Sound the alarm and report to command immediately!”

Wheeeeeeng!

The humans’ shouts and the wail of the emergency siren carried on the wind.

But the order had already been given. Nothing could stop the undead legion now that it had begun its advance.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

The ranks and files were arranged with military precision.

Death Knights and Dullahans led the way, with highly mobile Lycanthropes and other monsters holding the front line. Large monsters such as ogres, Trolls, and Golems advanced behind them like a colossal wall.

The monsters capable of using bows and magic had already moved to the rear.

The Black Knight was the one who had devised the discipline and formations ordinary monsters lacked.

Where did I learn such things?

Setting the question aside once more, the Black Knight opened his mouth.

"Follow."

At its master's will, the skeletal warhorse beneath him began to move.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

Hooves of white bone trampled the new shoots beneath them. The undead legion blanketing the vast breadbasket advanced slowly behind its commander.

Tremors shook the earth. The legion moved forward like a slow swell, then became a wave of bones sweeping across the plain.

Thudthudthudthudthud!

—Graaaargh!

Tens of thousands of monsters roared as one.

At the head of the monsters surging toward the city, the Black Knight shot forward like a streak of light.

"That one's the leader!"

"Ranged units! Prepare!"

"Tanks, stay calm! The armored units will intercept him alongside the Hunters!"

Tanks, armored units, Hunters.

The Black Knight heard the humans' shouts and, astonishingly, understood them perfectly.

He even knew what command would come next.

"Begin concentrated fire!"

Rat-a-tat-tat-tat!

Boom-boom-boom!

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

It was dazzling. Flames, ice, and flashes of light erupted from all across the city.

Some attacks came crashing down in graceful arcs. Others flew in nearly straight lines, aimed at the Black Knight and the undead knights following behind him.

"Ah."

Even in a world dyed gray, the light they gave off was enchanting and familiar. The Black Knight felt an inexplicable stirring within him and reached out.

Shrring.

The greatsword strapped to his back slid free.

Before the shells, magic, and arrows could reach him, the pitch-black blade carved through the air in every direction.

Kraaaash!

A gale of magical power swept across the battlefield. Space split apart. Spells blazing with brilliant mana went out like candle flames, and arrows shattered to pieces.

Everyone in the city watched as light was devoured by darkness.

The same thought flashed through Choi Minwoo's and Xiao Shen's minds.

This is…

Impossible to stop.

An insight approaching certainty.

Then, in the next moment, a pitch-black flash leaped across space and struck the Hunters.

KABOOM!

A thunderous roar rang out as though the sky itself had split apart.

Dozens of Tower Shields shattered, and sprays of blood burst into the air. Having cut down three A-rank Hunters and twenty B-rank Hunters with a single sword stroke, the Black Knight stared at the frozen humans through glowing red eyes.

From beneath his low-drawn helmet came the chilling voice of the dead.

"Aksar. Garosh."

Kill them all.

The Demon Realm words had been the last thing heard by those who died here the previous day.

And…

They were the Black Knight's command to the legion behind him.

"Your command."

"We obey."

Two Death Knights appeared to his left and right. A hundred Dullahans charged in behind them, becoming a sharp awl that pierced the human wall.

Krrrunch!

An ambush?

Emergency reports had come in from every front. Wei Fenghu roared, demanding to know what had happened, but the only answer he received was that communications with every front had been completely severed.

“Completely severed? They may have been unstable, but haven’t we still been able to connect since last night?”

The communications officer answered, drenched in cold sweat.

“W-we don’t know why, but the communications interference has grown even stronger. The emergency report that just arrived was confirmed to be from approximately thirty minutes ago.”

“…!”

What? Thirty minutes?

If that was true, the attacks had begun while the meeting was in progress.

And since the report had barely made it through the interference, it might not have been thirty minutes ago. It could have been an hour.

Magic Johnson muttered with his face gone rigid.

“That can’t be. It wasn’t nearly this bad before I left…”

Suddenly, the words Magic Johnson had spoken before leaving the city flashed through my mind.

“The Arch Lich’s power is gradually weakening. A considerable portion of the interference has disappeared since last night in particular.”

Wrong.

The Arch Lich’s power over the surrounding area hadn’t weakened. He had merely made it look that way.

Little by little, without giving anything away. Then, by withdrawing the legion, he had made it seem as if the range of his influence had shrunk dramatically—so that we could let our guard down even a little more.

This is…

A meticulously laid trap.

I didn’t know how the Arch Lich had realized the S-rank Hunters were gone. What mattered was that he had seized that brief opening and sent the monster legions forward.

The thought of the horrific slaughter we had witnessed the day before now unfolding across every front made my stomach churn even worse than it had during my first teleportation.

But this time, instead of throwing up, I grabbed Magic Johnson and said,

“Teleport.”

“What?”

“Teleport. Hurry!”

I expected Magic Johnson to use magic immediately. But his answer was nothing like what I had expected.

“Jin. Take a jet.”

“What? A jet? Why are you suddenly…? We’ll be too late.”

"It's too risky right now."

"Why? You know the coordinates of the hospital rooftop where we were earlier."

Magic Johnson shook his head.

"The coordinates aren't the problem. If we attempt to teleport like this…we could both die."

"…!"

In my desperation, I had momentarily forgotten about the Arch Lich's magical interference. There was no way the bastard who had laid such a trap would kindly allow us to teleport.

Magic Johnson continued in a subdued voice.

"Ten minutes. Twenty at most. Take the jet, Jin."

"…A lot of people will die in that time."

"Yes. But if you get yourself killed for nothing during the teleportation, there'll be even more casualties."

An S-rank Hunter was a strategic weapon capable of turning the tide of a war.

Even if I arrived late, I might still be able to save some people. But if something went wrong during the teleportation, there would be no saving me or the countless people left without reinforcements.

Magic Johnson was worried about me, but he was also pointing that out.

"It's brave, but foolish."

"…"

"The jet will be ready for takeoff soon. We don't have time for this."

Through the bulletproof glass covering one wall of the conference room, I could see pilots crossing the runway and boarding their aircraft.

I could also see the backs of the other S-rank Hunters, who had already left the conference room.

I watched in silence, then suddenly spoke.

"You said it was possible, right?"

"What?"

"Teleporting missiles, like in the hologram footage we saw earlier."

Magic Johnson's eyes widened.

"Jin, don't tell me…"

"There's no need for you to risk yourself too, Johnson. Sending me alone will be enough."

"Good God. Are you crazy? I explained it to you, and you still don't understand!"

"I understand perfectly. I'm prepared to take that risk."

"You…"

His lips moved as though he were about to say something, but then he suddenly slammed his fist down on the table.

Bang!

The expensive hardwood shattered beneath the force of his blow.

“Damn it! Fuck this whole goddamn mess!”

I let out a quiet laugh as I watched Magic Johnson mutter curse after curse.

I already knew what his reaction meant.

“I can take that as permission, right?”

“Yes, you insolent little brat.”

His bloodshot eyes fixed on me.

He looked ready to unleash another torrent of abuse.

Magic Johnson was genuinely furious—and at the same time, deeply saddened.

“Listen, Jin. I…”

“I know. You have people you need to protect too. I’m sorry to ask this of you.”

“…Damn it. Is sending you to the hospital rooftop enough?”

“Yes. That’s enough.”

Swoosh.

Magic Johnson clenched his teeth and pressed his thick palm against my chest.

As though taking every possible precaution, his mana slowly began to envelop my body, unlike the first time he had teleported me.

“Ten percent. That’s your chance of survival. There’s a ninety percent chance you could die.”

Ten percent…

I raised my head and looked up at the sky beyond the window.

A clear blue expanse without a single cloud. Was Murim somewhere in the distant universe beyond that sky? Were they waiting for me?

At that moment, a thought suddenly occurred to me, and the corners of my mouth lifted.

“That’s not bad. Ten percent is enough.”

“What?”

A dazzling mass of light burst forth. Feeling warmth envelop my entire body, I continued.

“It’s probably a thousand times higher than the odds of crossing dimensions.”

“…!”

I wondered what expression Magic Johnson was wearing by then.

I wanted to know, but unfortunately, I could no longer see his face. A blinding flash filled my vision, and a rough, powerful force sucked me through the warping space.

Whoooosh!

Chapter 397

Team Leader Choi—or rather, Choi Minwoo—thought,

What should I do?

His heart pounded wildly, but his mind was ice-cold.

Only thirty minutes had passed since the battle began. The hastily constructed defensive line had collapsed the instant the fighting started, then been torn apart as the highest-grade monsters slipped through the gaps and ran rampant without meeting any resistance.

Just like now.

Crunch!

Sharp fangs tore savagely into a human throat.

The Lycanthrope tossed aside the Hunter, whose last breath escaped in a wheeze, and let out a roar.

—Awooooooo!

Those became the Lycanthrope's final words.

Whoosh! Slash!

Its gray fur turned red as its body toppled sideways. Choi Minwoo took its head off with a clean strike, then bent backward without a moment to catch his breath.

Whoooooom! Crack!

The blow missed him by a handspan.[1920]

An ax blade rippling with ominous magical power grazed past Choi Minwoo and smashed the heads of two nearby Orcs.

The headless knight, a Dullahan, attacked the human in front of it without the slightest hesitation, despite having killed fellow monsters.

Swooooooosh! Slash!

—Krrk!

"Guh!"

As the enormous halberd swept back and forth, the humans and monsters caught within its reach were hacked to pieces.

A Dullahan was an A-rank monster that required three Hunters of the same rank to handle safely.

But Choi Minwoo slipped past its attack and thrust out his sword without hesitation.

Now!

A short exhalation.

[1920] A *ppyeom* is a handspan, the distance between the tips of an outstretched thumb and little finger. It varies by person; roughly 20 cm (8 in).

Then a strike like a flash of light.

Thud!

The blade, enchanted with three different spells and forged by a Master Artisan, pierced the Dullahan through the shoulder.

It might not feel pain, having already died once and become undead, but its body was still human.

The muscles and tendons in its right arm were severed, and the halberd dropped heavily to the ground. Choi Minwoo did not miss the opening.

Shhhhhk!

A white blade of aura cleaved the Dullahan in half at the waist. It must not have been dead for long, because rotten blood sprayed from its collapsing body and splattered across Choi Minwoo's face.

But despite the overpowering stench stabbing at his nose, he did not so much as twitch an eyebrow.

Choi Minwoo was gripped by the tension of the battlefield, cold reason, and a faint exhilaration.

That makes ten.

That was how many A-rank monsters Choi Minwoo had defeated by himself today. Including those of lower grades, the number had to be well over fifty.

Was I always this strong?

If he answered that question honestly, the answer was no.

Perhaps because of the Arch Lich's influence, the monsters he had encountered in China were slightly stronger and far more ferocious.

Even so, Choi Minwoo had been able to distinguish himself in such a chaotic battle because he had been blessed with two strokes of luck.

The first was—

The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.

The Mana Cultivation Method he had learned directly from Jin Taekyung.

Choi Minwoo had his doubts about Jin Taekyung's claim that it was a family heirloom passed down through generations. But he had no doubt whatsoever that it was an outstanding secret technique.

The Jin Family's Cultivation Technique allowed him to control his energy reliably while greatly improving how he distributed his strength. The immense mana he had gained while learning it also gave him the stamina to keep fighting without tiring easily.

And his second stroke of luck was—

—Gwoooooar!

Boom!

A length of rebar swung with berserk force and smashed through the concrete road.

Choi Minwoo stepped on the ogre's thick arm and sprang upward, bringing his sword down with all his strength.

Thrust!

The aura-infused blade split the ogre's crown as easily as tofu.

Thud.

The four-meter[1921] giant dropped to its knees with a heavy crash. Standing on the dead creature's shoulder, Choi Minwoo quickly swept his gaze over his surroundings.

He's not here.

Screams and death filled the hellish scene on every side.

But the monster was nowhere to be seen. The monster who had displayed unbelievable power the moment the battle began—the commander of the monster army and leader of the Death Knights.

Where the hell is he?

Choi Minwoo clearly remembered the Black Knight sweeping aside dozens of Hunters with a single blow.

If the creature had truly committed itself to the battle, the humans might have been annihilated before they lasted even thirty minutes.

But for some reason, the Black Knight had not appeared again.

Was it the monster's arrogance? Did it consider the battle too insignificant to warrant its involvement?

Choi Minwoo could not understand it. But the Black Knight's absence was both his second stroke of luck and his final chance to make a decision.

We have to retreat.

The urban battle had already lost all meaning. The monster army, numbering around ten thousand, had already covered the city like a swarm of ants. Among them were more than a hundred A-rank monsters.

The humans were outmatched in both numbers and strength.

Nearly half of the thousand Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department who had held the front line were already dead or wounded. And more than half of the damned People's Liberation Army had thrown down their weapons and fled before the monsters even reached them.

The armored units, reduced to heaps of scrap metal, and the air force, becoming prey for the flying monsters, were simply more of the same.

Rat-a-tat-tat-tat-tat! Boom!

[1921] Four meters is about 13 ft.

A state-of-the-art combat helicopter lost its balance and plunged from the sky, exploding in flames. Around a dozen soldiers caught in the flying debris died without even having time to scream.

It was a horrifying sight, but they were fortunate in one respect: their deaths had been painless.

A moment later, the monster horde began tearing everyone else apart indiscriminately.

—Kraaaaaaang!

Whoom! Crack!

The foreleg of a Saber Tiger, carrying several tons[1922] of force, crushed a soldier's limbs and burst his head.

The soldiers of the People's Liberation Army were nowhere near as fast as Hunters, and the rifles they carried were little better than slingshots against the monsters.

Choi Minwoo clenched his teeth at the merciless slaughter unfolding before him.

Get a grip. You can't save all of them.

He did not hypocritically preach about sacrificing the few for the many. He simply faced the situation with a cold eye and prepared himself to play the villain.

Could we have stopped them if he'd come?

Jin Taekyung suddenly came to mind, but that was nothing more than futile regret.

Even after he hounded the communications officer into frantically transmitting emergency signals, there had been no response.

A carefully planned surprise attack combined with thorough communications interference.

For now, all he could do was hope that one of the countless glass bottles cast into the sea would somehow reach Jin Taekyung.

Thud!

Choi Minwoo drove his sword into the chest of a charging Minotaur and shouted,

"Xiao Shen!"

His mana-infused voice pierced through the screams and thunderous crashes and reached one person's ears.

Covered in wounds and blood as he fought back the endless stream of monsters, Xiao Shen answered with a battle cry.

"Speak!"

"Withdraw the Public Security Armed Forces Department. We have to retreat now!"

"What? But if we retreat now…"

[1922] A metric ton is 1,000 kg (about 2,200 lb).

Choi Minwoo already knew what the young Hunter was about to say.

Retreats—and the pursuits that followed—were when the greatest number of casualties occurred.

Especially in a situation like this. If the Hunters serving as the last line of defense withdrew, the People's Liberation Army would fall straight into the monster army's grasp.

"If we're surrounded, it's all over. Do you understand? Take the surviving Hunters and the rear units and get out of the city while you still can!"

"…Mr. Choi."

"I know what you're thinking. But we have no other choice."

"…!"

Xiao Shen squeezed his eyes shut without realizing it.

He knew what the situation was. No—he understood it better than almost anyone.

The tide had turned sharply against them from the moment the battle began, and the humans had been driven all the way back to the hospital they were using as a temporary command center. If the monsters completed their encirclement—

Annihilation.

His deliberation felt long, but only a moment passed.

Xiao Shen opened his eyes and shouted with all his strength as he deflected the attacks raining down on him.

"Retreat! All Public Security Armed Forces Department personnel, withdraw immediately! The North Gate is open!"

In wartime, the orders of a commander like Xiao Shen were absolute.

All the more so when the military leadership, including General Liao, had not even shown their faces.

Good.

The soldiers might not have much hope, but the Hunters' odds of survival would rise dramatically. If Xiao Shen made the right calls, many of them might break through the encirclement and survive.

Yes. This is enough.

Feeling his heart grow lighter, Choi Minwoo launched himself forward.

Not toward the North Gate, which the monsters had yet to block, but toward the People's Liberation Army being slaughtered by the monsters.

It feels like I'm going to kill myself.

Why had he made this choice? Even he could not understand it.

Still…

For a man heading to his death, he felt surprisingly good.

Perhaps because dark clouds had gathered overhead, the wind was cool. And behind him, he had companions who would die alongside him, so he would not have to die alone.

Choi Minwoo suddenly spoke.

“Why didn’t you retreat?”

Xiao Shen, who should have been heading toward the North Gate, gave him a faint smile.

“What about you, Mr. Choi?”

“…I asked first.”

“Then I suppose I should answer first. Public Security Armed Forces Department!”

At the regimental commander’s call, the roughly three hundred Hunters following behind him let out a thunderous shout.

“To eliminate monsters and protect the people from every threat!”

“This is why we do not retreat. The 325 members of the Sichuan Province Public Security Armed Forces Department’s 1st Regiment, led by Regimental Commander Xiao Shen, have come to protect the people!”

Xiao Shen continued in a quiet voice.

“Now it’s your turn to answer, Mr. Choi.”

Choi Minwoo silently gazed at the thousands of monsters drawing closer, then suddenly muttered,

“Shit. There sure are a lot of them.”

“…!”

“That’s probably what he would have said. Then he would have fought harder than anyone else and won in the end.”

It was true. He had always been that way.

He had never backed down, no matter the situation, and he had never given up. Choi Minwoo had watched him longer and more closely than anyone else, so he knew.

That man, Jin Taekyung, was a hero of the new age. Choi Minwoo could never work miracles the way he did.

But still—

“It’s embarrassing.”

“What?”

“Jin Taekyung is technically my subordinate, you see. At a time like this, his superior ought to lead by example.”

Choi Minwoo burst into laughter, loudly enough to leave Xiao Shen bewildered.

His heart felt as light as a dandelion seed, and an unfamiliar power unlike anything he had ever felt before surged through his body as he shot toward the enemy.

Mr. Jin. I'll see you later.

If I survive today, as soon as possible.

If I die, as late as possible.

Let's meet then.

Hissssss.

The blade of his sword, filled with aura brighter and more radiant than ever, pointed toward the enemies.

The suicide squad of more than three hundred Hunters roared loud enough to deafen the ears, their fighting spirit surging as they shot forward behind him like arrows.

"Waaaaaaaaah!"

Two Death Knights who had been leading thousands of monsters in the slaughter of the People's Liberation Army looked down from their skeletal warhorses at the pitiful human force.

—Aksar. Garosh.

A moment later, the black wave swallowed the single white pebble.

The outcome had been decided from the beginning. Yet at the end of that battle, more fiercely fought than any before it, one man's sword had never lost its light.

The two Death Knights dropped to one knee before the Black Knight watching them.

—In the battle—

—we achieved victory.

—Today, this glory—

—we offer to our Lord.

Their voices were clipped and devoid of intonation. Even at the news of victory, the Black Knight merely nodded without interest.

It had gone as expected. The humans had been unable to stop his mighty legion and had collapsed in a single stroke.

But if asked whether everything had unfolded according to the Black Knight's wishes, the answer would have been no.

Those humans from before.

After breaking through the city and forcing the humans to retreat at the start of the battle, the Black Knight had turned his warhorse wherever the whim took him.

For some reason, he had returned to the strangely familiar place from the previous day, where he found something small.

Human? No. Not human. A child. And this is a shoe.

Memories and words surfaced one after another.

As the Black Knight had thought, it was a child's shoe—a tiny infant's shoe lost in the chaos and left behind without anyone realizing it had fallen.

The infinitely small, dirt-covered shoe seemed strangely familiar. Looking at it made his chest ache.

Hm? My chest aches?

What an unfamiliar expression.

The Black Knight's body had been incapable of feeling pain from the beginning. His master had personally created him and bestowed a powerful blessing upon him. Naturally, he never tired and felt no pain.

More importantly, this was no time to be swayed by something so trivial.

—Lord.

—Is something wrong?

He did not know why he had done it.

The Black Knight tucked the shoe into a gap in his armor and changed the subject.

—No. Rather, quite a few humans managed to escape alive.

—We apologize.

—It was our failure.

—There must be a reason.

The Death Knights bowed their heads deeply.

—The humans' resistance—

—was fiercer than expected.

—In exchange—

—we gained a small prize.

As if they had been waiting for those words, the densely packed monsters parted left and right to open a path.

A Troll approached cautiously, lowered the two figures slung over its shoulders, and stepped back.

The Black Knight's eyes flickered as he regarded the "small prize."

—They are humans.

—Yes.

The two loyal retainers answered in unison, then continued.

—Reap their souls yourself—

—and make them servants of our Lord.

—If you do so, Lord—

—you will grow even mightier.

They were right. Those two humans possessed rich, enticing souls.

If he personally reaped their souls and took them as subordinates, they would be reborn as even greater warriors. They might even prove worthy of commanding an entire force.

But—

Why?

The Black Knight realized that he was hesitating.

This was obviously something he had to do. Powerful subordinates would strengthen the legion, and strengthening the legion was an act of loyalty and devotion to the King of Death he served.

So why was he hesitating?

What is making me hesitate?

Ordinarily, he would have held back if something felt wrong. But the Black Knight had experienced this same confusion far too often of late.

The fact that he had forced himself to reach out might have been an act of defiance against himself.

—I will accept your suggestion.

Then, just as the Black Knight reached toward the two humans to reap their souls —

"I've been thinking about it carefully."

A voice rang out through the air, and the Black Knight raised his head.

Someone stood atop the half-burned, half-collapsed hospital, framed by sunlight streaming through the dark clouds behind him.

"Ten percent is surprisingly high when you think about it. Hmm. Definitely higher than my chances of getting a girlfriend."

The Black Knight's eyes narrowed. He recognized that energy. He had sensed it from afar the previous day.

At last, he had come face-to-face with the owner of that immense heat.

—Who are you?

"Me?"

Swish. Tap.

It happened in an instant. The young human dropped rapidly from a dizzying height, yet landed as lightly as a leaf. He pointed to himself with one finger and grinned.

"I'm one damn lucky bastard."

The next moment, the Black Knight saw it clearly.

The human's finger shifting to point at him.

And every trace of emotion vanishing from the human's face.

"You're, what…"

His voice was cold enough to make even the dead shudder.

“You’re one damn unlucky bastard.”

Chapter 398

Before attempting teleportation, a thought suddenly occurred to me.

If I put the odds of everything that's happened over the past two years into percentages, what would they be?

What were the odds that an F-rank Hunter, trudging uphill after being fired from his Guild, would find an old capsule abandoned at a recycling station?

What were the odds that the capsule would turn out to be a passage to another world?

What were the odds that I would begin my second life as the Third Young Master of a frontier martial family—not as a member of the Namgung Family or a direct Disciple of Huashan?

What were the odds that I would survive one war, two bloody massacres, and more brushes with death than I could count…?

After considering all of that, I reached a single conclusion.

"Ten percent is enough after all."

With that quiet murmur, I reached out.

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space.

Three jiazi[1923] of internal energy pulled Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen toward me. The Death Knights and monsters tried to move, but stopped when their leader raised a hand.

Ignoring them, I checked the two men's condition. Their breathing was faint, and their qi was so precarious it seemed ready to vanish at any moment.

If I had taken a jet instead of teleporting, I might have been too late forever.

"I would've tried even with a one-percent chance. I'm not the kind of guy who dies for nothing."

Of course, I had also taken out some insurance in case the worst happened. I just hadn't expected to use it so soon, let alone under circumstances like these.

Open Inventory. Summon.

I paid no attention to the monsters watching me.

The leader saw me pull the item I needed from my Inventory and asked in a flat voice,

"An extradimensional space. Have you learned Magic?"

Shut your fucking mouth.

I swallowed the words hovering on the tip of my tongue. Normally, that would have been quite difficult, but right now, it wasn't.

I did not want anyone to interfere with me. At least not right now.

[1923] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar.

Pop.

When I removed the magically sealed stopper, a faint fragrance drifted out. Milky liquid sloshed inside the clear glass bottle.

A Top-Grade Potion.

A miraculous medicine said to heal any injury as long as the patient was still breathing.

Right now, I couldn't have cared less about the rarity or value of the scant hundred milliliters[1924] in that bottle.

I simply thanked Wu Heixing for being both fabulously wealthy and incredibly stupid, then let the potion trickle between the lips of the patient lying there like a corpse.

Hang on a little longer, Shen.

Team Leader Choi came first. Partly because of all the time we had spent together, but even if we had shared no bond at all, I would still have chosen him first.

That was how serious Team Leader Choi's injuries were.

This is…

His left arm had been torn away from the shoulder. His right ankle was mangled as if something had chewed and swallowed it, while his left leg had been cleanly amputated. Seven ribs were broken, and his spine was fractured.

And…

His right hand, twisted at an unnatural angle, still clutched the hilt of his sword.

The leather strap he had fastened tightly around it so he wouldn't lose his grip was soaked through with blood.

"…"

I silently undid the strap, pried the sword from his crushed hand, and set it beside him.

I didn't forget to scold him in my head.

Why did you do this? It's a miracle you're still alive.

Then the real miracle began.

When I carefully tilted the bottle and administered exactly half of it, a sound like something burning filled the air, and the wounds covering Team Leader Choi's entire body began to heal.

Hisssssss, hisssssss—

Bones regrew, severed muscles rejoined, and damaged organs and flesh knitted together.

He recovered even faster than a Troll, the very embodiment of regeneration. As if time itself had been reversed, color finally began returning to Team Leader Choi's face.

[1924] One hundred milliliters is about 3.4 US fluid ounces.

His qi has stabilized too. This should be enough.

I couldn't have asked for a better result.

The others watching, however, were far less pleased.

"Fearless human."

"Stop at once."

"They have been granted the destiny—"

"of becoming subservient to our mighty Lord."

I silently regarded the two Death Knights who stepped forward in place of their leader.

Clad from head to toe in pitch-black armor, they looked almost like twins. They were roughly the same height, and even their voices were difficult to tell apart.

There was only one obvious difference between them: the weapons at their waists.

One has a mace. The other has a sword.

That was enough to give me my answer. I had solved the question; I could write down the answer later.

Right now, I had another problem to deal with.

"You've been through hell too, Shen."

Xiao Shen wasn't as badly injured as Team Leader Choi, but his wounds were still severe. I was about to pour the remaining half of the potion into his mouth when —

"Wretched human."

"This is your final warning."

"Put down those two humans, step back, and beg for mercy."

"Then our Lord will take you as his servant."

"A servant?"

"Yes."

One of the Death Knights stepped toward me, its voice flat and emotionless. The scabbard secured at its waist swayed with every step.

Clank. Clank. Clank.

One step. Two steps. Three.

There wasn't a trace of hesitation in its approach.

Thousands of monsters and their leader were watching.

The Death Knight spoke with such confidence that it was hard to believe it was an emotionless undead monster.

"You possess a truly great and radiant soul. Become one of us."

A great and radiant soul…

Without even raising my head, I continued pouring the potion.

Once the last few drops had fallen into Xiao Shen's mouth, I stoppered the empty bottle and returned it to my Inventory.

Hissssss, hissssss.

A signal that recovery had begun.

I straightened at the welcome sound I had been waiting for, looked at the Death Knight, and finally said what I'd been wanting to say.

"His left leg."

"Hm?"

"Team Leader Choi's left leg. Everything below a point one handspan[1925] beneath the knee was gone. Cut off clean. And Xiao Shen—that young kid lost his right arm."

"Human. What are you trying to say?"

"What am I trying to say?"

I gave it a faint smile.

"If you cut off perfectly good limbs, you should've been prepared for what came next."

And in the next instant—

In the sliver of time left after an instant had been split in half, then split again, the creature was suddenly right in front of me.

No.

It was the other way around.

It hadn't come to me.

I had gone to it.

"Let's see that vaunted skill of yours."

"…!"

Everything happened at once. The Death Knight tried to draw its sword, and I reached out with my left hand and pressed firmly against the back of its hand.

That was both the beginning and the end.

Shing. Click!

The dark blade had barely cleared its scabbard before it was forced back inside.

By then, my fist had already punched through the creature's chest.

Crunch!

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, charged with the Scorching Yang Qi of three jiazi[1926], vaporized even the fistful of blood remaining inside the undead monster and blazed up using its long-dead body as kindling.

Whoosh! Rooooar!

[1925] A handspan is the distance between the tips of an outstretched thumb and little finger. It varies by person but is roughly 20 cm, or 8 in.

[1926] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar.

Engulfed in flames that refused to die, the Death Knight flailed its arms and turned toward its kin.

It staggered back along the path it had strode down so confidently, then crumbled into ash.

"…!"

"…!"

Though thousands of monsters were gathered there, everything went silent as if someone had pressed a mute button.

I took White Flame from my Inventory and slowly began to walk.

Splash. Splash.

Everywhere I looked and everywhere I stepped, there were corpses and blood.

Countless rifles caught against my feet. A soldier in a crooked combat helmet stared at the sky with lifeless eyes.

At least his corpse was still intact.

In what appeared to have been the fiercest part of the battlefield, Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department lay dead, their bodies mangled beyond recognition.

I had spent a full week with the 1st Regiment under Xiao Shen. Among the corpses were several faces I recognized.

So many died. So damn many.

At least three thousand humans had died here today alone.

How many would that number become if I added the dead from all five fronts? If I included the civilians killed in this Monster Wave?

Thud!

I borrowed an unknown Hunter's spear and drove it deep into the ground. Team Leader Choi's leather strap, tied securely to the end of the shaft, fluttered in the wind.

Beyond it stood an army of thousands of monsters—and *him.*

Death Knight Lord.

What a grand name. Then again, the monster possessed enough power to live up to it.

The circumstances are different, but I do have another one like him.

I called out to the creature currently setting a new record for silence.

"Let me ask you a favor."

I expected him to pretend he hadn't heard, but after a brief hesitation, the Skeleton Warlord answered.

"…A favor? You're not asking me to fight beside you, are you?"

"Of course not."

I had never expected that of him, and I didn't now. The favor I wanted had nothing to do with fighting.

It was about protecting someone.

"Protect the two people behind me. No matter what it takes."

With my permission, the Skeleton Warlord had been absorbing death qi whenever possible, growing stronger in the process.

As a Named Monster, he should have been capable of handling several ordinary A-rank monsters by himself.

"When this battle is over, I'll grant you any wish."

"In that case, there's nothing I can't do. But how long am I supposed to protect them?"

"That's obvious…"

I raised White Flame and pointed it at the Death Knight Lord.

"Until every last one of those bastards is dead."

"You lunatic…!"

"Too late."

I pulled the Skeleton Warlord's skull from my Inventory and tossed it behind me.

Crack. Pop.

As he hurriedly regenerated his body, I stroked the leather strap fluttering from the spear shaft.

How had he felt?

How had they all felt?

What had gone through their minds as they charged toward their deaths?

I couldn't begin to imagine.

There was only one thing I knew for certain.

"Any bastard who comes past this spear is going to fucking die."

The fire dragon coiled within my dantian raised its head.

CRUNCH!

Flesh and bone shattered, spraying in every direction.

An ogre's limbs went flying, while a Troll was engulfed in unquenchable flames before it had a chance to regenerate.

Boom! Slash!

The head of a Lycanthrope baring its fangs exploded.

A Dullahan charged through the spray of foul-smelling brain matter, only to be cleaved in half with a single blow. Its halberd found a new master and shot away with tremendous force, tearing through a Wyvern's wing.

CRACKLE!

"Kyaaaaaaa!"

Thud-thud-thud!

Blood rained from the sky.

At the same moment, a streak of blue flame cut through the downpour.

Whoooooosh! Slash!

A storm of blood erupted. Whenever the flames streaked through the air, dozens of monsters fell and hundreds recoiled.

And the thousands of monsters…

At some point, they began to be overwhelmed.

They had grown afraid of a single human—and of the line of death he had drawn with a single spear.

"L-Lord."

For the first time, the Death Knight's flat, unwavering voice trembled with emotion.

The Black Knight knew perfectly well what his subordinate's desperate plea meant.

"Make way."

Between the slits of the deeply lowered helmet, red eyes flickered.

As he advanced, immense magical power rolling off him, he tried to ignore the strange words and scenes that kept surfacing in his mind.

Nothing could take precedence over his creator, his eternal lord.

"Are you listening, my servant?"

At his lord's voice echoing like a hallucination, the Black Knight quietly replied,

"Yes, my lord."

Until the very end, he failed to realize one thing.

That his hand was groping somewhere between the plates of his armor.

Chapter 399

Whoosh!

Nothing could stop the spearhead wreathed in Force—not leather that could deflect bullets, nor flesh and bone harder than steel.

Puh-puh-puk!

Big targets came with a bonus. The spearhead punched through the Lycanthrope's chest and skewered the monsters packed close behind it like meat on a spit.

"Krrgh, k-kek."

Its wide eyes held a mixture of confusion and indignation.

Its gaze seemed to protest: *Why me, out of all these monsters? I never crossed the death line you drew.*

"No."

I quietly pulled on the shaft.

Scrape. The Lycanthrope's claws raked across the ground as I dragged it over to my side of the spear.

"You crossed it. Just now."

"…!"

That was far enough. I yanked the spear free at lightning speed and swept it horizontally across the monsters before me.

Whoosh, KRAAAASH!

Blue flames scorched the air as they surged forward and swallowed the monsters.

Those still alive burned to death screaming, while those already turned undead crumbled to ash.

Ding. Ding. Ding…

System notifications announcing my kills rang out without pause.

How many had fallen to that single strike? Dozens? A hundred?

Rather than count them one by one, I chose to keep moving. My goal had never been to kill some fixed number of monsters.

Annihilation.

Humans and monsters had been locked in this fated struggle to kill or be killed for decades.

Only one species would be able to survive here today, and I would not be the one to fall.

Thud.

I stepped over the spear embedded deep in the concrete. At the same moment, countless monsters retreated as if by prior agreement.

One step. Two steps. Three.

No matter how far I walked, the distance between us did not shrink. For every step I took, they backed away by just as much.

“This is insane…”

Behind me, the Skeleton Warlord muttered as if groaning.

One human was overwhelming an army of thousands of monsters.

Even if this sight wasn’t enough to fill a page in human history, surely it deserved at least a paragraph.

“W-Where are you going?”

“Keep a good eye on those two. I’m not going far anyway.”

More precisely, there was no longer any need for me to go far.

The guest had already arrived. There was no reason to go out and meet him.

He’s finally here.

My guess had been right. The monster army parted left and right like the ebbing tide, revealing *him* in the distance atop a skeletal horse made entirely of black bones.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

He wore pitch-black full plate armor, and a vivid red glow shone beneath his low-set helmet.

He was far smaller than a large monster like an ogre, but the mana pouring from him was immense and powerful.

Level 135. It was a number I had never seen on any monster I had faced before.

As the Death Knight Lord approached, slowly gathering speed, a thought occurred to me.

Can I defeat him?

My battle with the Western Heaven Demon Lord in Murim had been a desperate struggle with my life on the line.

If the Western Heaven Demon Lord had intended to eliminate me from the very beginning, if the Heavenly Power Demon had not passed his internal energy to me, if I had not experienced that miraculous recovery from leveling up, if Jeok Cheongang had not awakened and saved me at the critical moment, I would have died three or four times over.

But in the end, I had survived—and grown stronger.

That was when a question had begun circling endlessly through my mind.

How strong am I now?

The System said my martial arts realm and stats had risen.

I had distributed my stats and fought battles just as I always had, but aside from gaining Force, I wasn't sure what had changed.

I had no real sense of how much stronger I had become.

At some point, it had all become easy and natural.

And now—

Clatter, thud-thud-thud!

As I watched the Death Knight Lord shoot toward me like a gust of wind, I realized the answer.

The immense mana cascading from his body like a waterfall did not shake me in the slightest. That alone told me.

I am…

Whoooooosh!

The wind vanished, replaced by a flash of light. The Death Knight Lord and his skeletal horse charged as one, and the sword in his hand moved.

Dense darkness gathered around the blade and came crashing down, yet the sight unfolded so slowly before my eyes that a single certainty surfaced in my mind.

I am stronger than anyone else on this battlefield.

In that slowed-down world, I thrust out White Flame.

Blue-white flames surged along the spearhead and devoured the darkness.

A roar like the sky splitting apart rang out.

KRAAAASH!

The ground within a radius of several hundred meters[1927] caved in, and the hospital that had stood firm for decades collapsed.

Compressed air erupted in layer after layer like a sonic boom, battering and hurling away everything around them.

And at the center of it all stood two beings whom no one else could approach.

Whoosh, whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! KABOOM!

Several times—perhaps dozens—in the blink of an eye.

Whenever blue-white flames and pitch-black darkness collided and mingled, deafening roars and devastating destruction followed.

No human or monster could see the movements of the two beings.

They existed on another level, clashing within a world and time all their own.

Swish!

The silver-white spear in Jin Taekyung's hand slashed down through empty space.

[1927] Several hundred meters is roughly several hundred yards; 300 m is about 980 ft.

Blue-white flames tore through space as they poured downward. But the Black Knight did not retreat. He swung his sword.

KABOOM!

The instant the surging mana collided with the flames, the tremendous pressure shattered the Black Knight's skeletal horse.

But the erasure of Nightmare—his loyal steed and an A-rank monster—was nothing compared to what came next.

Whoooooosh!

A thrown spear with no preparatory motion whatsoever—a veritable flash of light.

The Black Knight twisted aside on instinct. Tremendous heat grazed his chest and tore into the ranks of monsters behind him.

KRAKAKAK! KABOOM!

The spearhead punched through dozens of monsters before slamming into the ground, where it blasted out a massive crater with a thunderous roar.

Before the monsters caught in the aftermath could even scream in terror, Jin Taekyung was already moving toward the Black Knight.

Sshk.

A single step, without sound or presence.

By the time the Black Knight noticed, Jin Taekyung had erased the dozens of meters[1928] between them and reached his target. A fist shot toward the Black Knight's chest.

"Get lost."

"…!"

Boom!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist. Heat hotter than lava slammed into the armor.

The Black Knight was hurled away at tremendous speed, but he flipped in midair and righted himself. At the same time, his hand tightened around his sword hilt and swept the blade out with tremendous force.

Whoooooosh! Shh-shh-shhk!

Black mana became dozens of lightning bolts that shot toward Jin Taekyung. Each one possessed earth-shaking power.

But Jin Taekyung was already gone.

KRAKABOOM!

Jin Taekyung burst through the cloud of pale dust and extended both hands.

The sword had already changed direction and was slashing down toward the crown of his head, but he caught the blade between his palms as if clasping his hands in prayer.

[1928] Dozens of meters is a distance measured in tens of yards; 20 m is about 66 ft.

Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade.

His hands, wreathed in blue flames, and the blade, laden with immense mana, trembled between the two beings.

One blocking. The other pressing forward.

Their fierce deadlock brought the relentless exchange to a momentary halt—until an unexpected intruder broke it.

"You! Human!"

A Death Knight appeared with a shout and brought its mace down toward Jin Taekyung's back.

Boom!

The Death Knight never even realized when or how it died.

Jin Taekyung's heel sliced through the air like a blade and blew its head apart, helmet and all.

Thud.

Yet futile though its erasure had been, the attack was not entirely meaningless.

The Black Knight's red eyes flashed, and the sword in his grasp unleashed more mana than ever before.

The tiniest of openings.

The instant in which Jin Taekyung diverted his internal energy to kill the Death Knight was enough to shatter the balance.

Crunch! Slash!

Blood sprayed into the air.

It was endlessly red—human blood, proof that the Black Knight's sword had cut across Jin Taekyung's chest.

A single certainty flashed through the Black Knight's mind.

It's over.

Then, in the next instant, Jin Taekyung's flame-wreathed fist slammed into the Black Knight's side.

Crack!

"…!"

The Death Knight Lord's body jerked.

Like any undead monster incapable of feeling pain, he made no sound, but I could read the question in the red glow visible through the slits of his helmet.

How?

Yeah. That was exactly what his eyes were asking.

I answered flatly.

“You think you’re the only one with armor?”

Boom!

This time, it was the Flame Divine Palm.

Already cracked from the repeated blows, the Death Knight Lord’s armor shattered into fragments.

“That hurt, you son of a bitch.”

Crack!

I seized his gauntleted wrist, twisted it, and snapped it.

I had no idea how much attacks like these mattered against an undead monster, but it was enough to make him drop his sword.

Clank.

The moment the sword hit the ground, the Death Knight Lord was met with a merciless barrage.

Boom! Crack! Bam!

I planted my foot on his instep and unleashed punch after punch.

Shoulder. Arm. Side. Chest.

The Death Knight Lord took dozens of blows in the blink of an eye. He tried to counterattack, but it didn’t matter.

Thud!

“…?”

“Don’t look so surprised. My armor’s pretty useful too.”

I had the Fire Dragon Armor.

Never thought I’d use it here.

The Fire Dragon Armor was a divine weapon I had obtained after defeating the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

It had been so severely damaged during the battle in Murim that it was still repairing itself, but even at a restoration rate of roughly fifty percent, it had done its job admirably.

Though I nearly died because it couldn’t block the strike completely.

My vision had swum when the sword cut me.

But I had suffered this much pain more times than I cared to remember.

Besides, it was nothing compared to the pain endured by those who had died before me.

“This is…for the people you killed today.”

I put all my strength into a punch and drove it into his face.

A Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist at the eighth level smashed apart the helmet that had withstood everything, revealing his face.

The balance had tipped. One blow. One final strike would be enough to take his life.

“And this is…”

At that moment, my raised fist stopped dead.

I blinked through eyelids clotted with blood. For just an instant, time seemed to stop when my gaze landed on someone’s face.

It was unfamiliar, yet familiar.

With deathly white skin and glowing red eyes, he looked exactly like a certain hero I had seen in a holographic video.

“…Lei Fei?”

Chapter 400

The moment he first clashed with Jin Taekyung, the black knight knew instinctively.

He's strong.

The young human before him was extraordinarily powerful. Even if the black knight fought with everything he had, victory was far from certain. His opponent might even be stronger than he was.

As the battle seesawed back and forth, that conviction only deepened.

This will be a difficult fight.

But the black knight neither feared him nor retreated.

He was his lord's most loyal servant, charged with carrying out his commands.

This was a battle between warriors who had transcended their limits. Even the slightest difference could decide the outcome.

If I don't give up, an opportunity will come.

The black knight knew that well.

He had repeated those words to himself ever since his childhood training. By surviving countless battles, he had grown into a mighty warrior.

…Me?

Confusion struck again. The moment his thoughts faltered, his movements became erratic.

And his opponent was neither weak nor careless enough to let such an opening pass.

Whoosh! Slash!

The spearhead tore through dead flesh.

Boom!

Blue flames slammed into his chest.

Amid the almost tangible heat, the black knight suddenly felt something.

Pain.

What is this…?

What unsettled him was not that he could feel pain, but that a sensation which should have been utterly foreign felt so terribly familiar.

What are these memories…?

His chest throbbed. His head pounded.

As the black knight staggered beneath the relentless barrage, memories belonging to someone he could not identify flashed rapidly before his eyes.

Th-This can't be!

"His mana adaptability is incredible. It's the highest figure we've ever recorded!"

“He must be enrolled in the Zhonghua Development Training program immediately!”

Humans dressed in dazzling white clothes chattered excitedly. Among them stood a middle-aged man in a dark, sharply tailored uniform.

“Zhonghua Development Training? You intend to raise that child as a Hunter?”

“Of course. He is only thirteen, yet his mana adaptability is comparable to Faye Chen’s. He has more than enough potential to become an S-rank Hunter—the greatest Hunter in our nation!”

“I refuse.”

“Pardon?”

“No, Comrade Lieutenant General. What do you mean? This child…”

“Enough.”

The middle-aged man continued in a subdued voice.

“He is my only nephew. I promised my sister I would make him happy, not turn him into a Hunter and put him in danger.”

“Being a Hunter is a noble calling. If that child becomes an S-rank Hunter, it will be a blessing to all our people!”

“I know how noble their work is. But that was how my brother-in-law…”

The middle-aged man suddenly stopped and shook his head.

“Nothing you say will change my mind. If not for the directive from above, I would never have allowed him to be tested. We’re leaving. The rest is up to you.”

“Comrade Lieutenant General! Comrade Lieutenant General!”

Leaving the shouts behind him, the middle-aged man strode over, forced a smile, and held out his hand.

“You’ve been waiting a long time, haven’t you? Come on. Let’s go.”

The black knight—or rather, the person whose memories these seemed to be—took the middle-aged man’s hand.

His own hand was small and pale.

Then a child’s clear voice rang out.

“Uncle.”

“Yes?”

“I… I want to become a Hunter.”

A host of emotions crossed the middle-aged man’s face.

He stared at the child for a long time, biting his lip. When he finally released a troubled sigh, the others approached with markedly brighter expressions.

“Zhonghua Development Training is a project we designed with the utmost care. Its safety measures are rigorous, and its effectiveness is proven. Wu Heixing is the same age, and he’s doing well.”

“If the child changes his mind, we’ll stop the training at any time.”

The oldest-looking man placed a hand on the middle-aged man's shoulder.

"Please trust us and leave him in our care, Comrade Lieutenant General Wei Fenghu."

Wei Fenghu. Wei Fenghu…

The name echoed endlessly through the black knight's mind.

It was so familiar.

He had missed it so much.

Boom!

Did his chest ache because of the blow he had taken, or was there another reason?

As the staggering black knight stared ahead, more memories appeared before his eyes.

"You think you're the best just because the adults praise you?"

A boy in a bow tie and black suit glared at him with sharp eyes. His polished shoes gleamed.

"Don't get the wrong idea. I'm the best. You're second!"

The black knight's vision tilted to one side, and then an innocent voice rang out.

"Okay. Let's do that, then."

"What?"

"I don't mind being second. Third is fine too, and I wouldn't care if I came in last."

The sharp-featured boy's mouth fell open.

"Are you stupid? You want to be even worse than Zhang Wei, the lowest-ranked trainee in the whole training camp?"

"But Zhang Wei is kind, and he's always helping others. He'll become a great Hunter."

"Y-You're making fun of me, aren't you?"

"Huh? No. I just meant that if that's what you want, then I'm fine with—ah!"

Crash!

It took only an instant to subdue the boy who had suddenly lunged at him. Pinned beneath him, the boy thrashed and shouted.

"I'm the best! Wu Heixing is the best at everything!"

As one memory faded, another surfaced, as though someone were tossing stones one after another into a still pond.

The memories of that unknown person continued to throw the black knight's mind into confusion.

"Top trainee, ■■■■, step forward."

A small number of people filled a vast space.

For some reason, he could not make out the name being called, but his body moved on its own.

Step. Step.

His disciplined strides were long, and his vantage point was much higher.

He had grown into a young man. An older man in uniform approached and pinned a medal to his chest.

It was a familiar face—the same man from the first memory. He leaned closer and whispered.

“Are you certain you won’t regret this?”

“I have no regrets. I never have, and I never will.”

“Most people will never know you exist. You may have to spend your entire life in the shadows.”

“I was taught that a Hunter is also a guardian. Remaining unseen does not diminish my honor.”

“There is something I have not been able to tell you until now.”

The older man’s grip tightened on his shoulder.

“I’m proud of you. Thank you for growing into such a fine man.”

“Thank you, Uncle. No… Father.”

The older man smiled brightly, his eyes glistening with tears.

The instant a single tear rolled down his wrinkled cheek and struck the platform, another memory surfaced.

“Hello? Is anyone here?”

The place he visited on that warm spring day was a small flower shop. As he looked around at the vibrant flowers and peered farther inside, she approached him.

“Welcome!”

Her steps were light and buoyant, her eyes prim and feline.

Her voice was so cheerful and bright.

And she was so beautiful…

The black knight—or rather, a man who had passed through his youthful years and grown more mature—felt his heart pound.

“Are you a customer?”

“N-No, I… I came to buy some fl-flowers.”

“For your parents? Or your girlfriend?”

“My parents. Strictly speaking, they aren’t my parents. It’s my uncle who raised me…”

“I see. You speak so formally, though. Are you a soldier?”

“S-Something like that.”

It was a strange memory. His words kept breaking off, and everything before his eyes repeatedly turned white.

When he came to his senses, he was walking dazedly into a hospital room with a bright bouquet in his arms.

“You fool. I told you there was no need to come when it’s only mild pneumonia… What’s that?”

At Wei Fenghu’s question, he answered blankly.

“Flowers.”

“Is that a get-well gift?”

“Yes.”

“So you bought me chrysanthemums as a get-well gift?”[1929]

“Yes… Huh?”

“You ungrateful brat! Hey, you!”

Smack! Smack!

The man laughed even as he was beaten with the bouquet. A quiet laugh escaped him at his own stupidity, and he could not help laughing because she looked like chrysanthemums.

After that, the memories sped by.

He visited the flower shop every day.

“H-Hello!”

“Welcome—oh, you’re back again?”

“Haha.”

“Chrysanthemums, right? The pure white ones.”

Spring, summer, autumn, winter.

By the time all four seasons had passed, they were no longer merely a flower-shop owner and her customer.

“I have something to tell you.”

“What is it?”

“Will you marry me?”

“…Oh.”

“I’ll make you happy.”

Of all the memories he had seen, that one lasted the longest.

After a silence so long that a single second felt like ten years, or even a hundred, she finally opened her mouth.

“I have something to tell you too.”

“No, before that, give me your answer…”

“I’m pregnant.”

“What?”

[1929] In China, white chrysanthemums are traditionally associated with funerals and mourning, making them an awkward choice for a get-well gift.

Thump. Thump-thump. Thump-thump-thump!

The man's heart hammered wildly, and the black knight writhed in agony.

"Aaah… Aaaaaah!"

His head hurt as if it were splitting apart, and it felt as though someone were wringing out his insides with their hands.

Along with pain beyond anything he had ever imagined, another memory forced its way into the empty space.

"Waaah! Waaah!"

"Th-This child…"

"Congratulations on becoming a father, honey."

The birth of a new life.

And its growth.

"Dada. Dada-da!"

"Honey, honey! Did you hear that? Our baby's already saying 'Dada.' Could our baby be a genius?"

"Could you change the diaper?"

"Wait. Let me hear it one more time."

"Dada! Momma!"

"Hahaha! That's right! We're your daddy and mommy!"

The day the baby, bundled in a swaddling cloth and squirming helplessly, succeeded in rolling over.

The day she first crawled on all fours.

The day she took her first steps…

The man was as happy as if the entire world belonged to him.

But it did not take long for those dreamlike days to become a nightmare.

"The magical power level in Gaoping District has spiked!"

"Gaoping District? Keep trying to contact them, and mobilize and deploy the Second Regiment as a precaution."

"D-Director, we've lost communications."

"What?"

Disaster struck without warning.

The man hurriedly assembled the forces under his command and headed for the source, only to find an unbelievable sight awaiting him.

"Kyaaaaaaa!"

"E-Everyone, run—guh!"

Crunch! KABOOM!

Flames billowed into the sky above the once-peaceful city, while countless monsters slaughtered people on the ground.

Before that unbelievable scene of carnage, in a land overflowing with screams and death, the man drew his sword.

“Public Security Armed Forces Department!”

Zzzzt!

An aura blade surged around his sword, shining brilliantly.

More than a thousand Hunters answered his cry with a deafening roar.

They were humanity’s shield and guardians.

They could not retreat a single step.

“Wipe them all out!”

“Waaaah! Long live the People’s Republic of China!”

With the Five-Starred Red Flag emblazoned on their armor, they surged forward like a wave—only to break apart in sprays of blood instead of white foam.

“Perish in the flames of hellfire. Fire Rain.”

Kiiiiing.

The ash-gray sky opened its maw.

Beneath the falling rain of fire, the man thought of his beloved wife and five-year-old daughter.

And then he came face-to-face with *that being*.

“If you had run, you could have lived.”

“I’ll kill you.”

“How noble. What is your name, human?”

“I am…”

“…Lei Fei?”

At the sound of Jin Taekyung’s voice, the black knight’s body went rigid.

The dam burst, and everything began to reassemble.

Thirty-six years of memories from his life as a human crashed over him like a tidal wave, blotting out his vision.

—I am… I am…

What in the world was he?

As the black knight trembled in confusion and pain, a thunderous voice rang through his mind.

—You are my most loyal servant and the supreme commander of my legion. Your lord commands you: fulfill your duty until you crumble into ash!

—…!

It was a word of power he could not resist.

The red light in his eyes, wavering like a candle in the wind, suddenly blazed.

The black knight—no, Lei Fei—had fallen with only one strike left to finish him. Now tremendous magical power erupted from his entire body.
KRAAAAAASH!

Chapter 401

A single word, almost a groan, slipped between my lips.

"…Lei Fei?"

Wei Fenghu's only nephew through his sister. An S-rank Hunter secretly trained by China.

And a hero who had vanished alongside a thousand Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department on the day the Monster Wave erupted.

If you happen to meet that child, Mr. Jin…would you be able to bring him back?

The old general's desperate request echoed in my ears. That was probably why my body suddenly froze.

—You wicked human! Get a grip! He is no longer human. He is a fallen monster!

The Skeleton Warlord was stating the obvious.

Among the monsters I had defeated so far were Hunters and civilians resurrected as undead. Lei Fei was merely one of them.

The being before me was no longer an S-rank Hunter who had died carrying out his mission. He was a Death Knight Lord leading a monster army.

But…

Something's different.

Crack, crack, crack!

—Kgh, k-khgh. Kraaah!

His body trembled in tiny spasms, groans escaping him at irregular intervals.

Each time the red glow in his eyes flickered like a traffic light, stark-white irises and pupils appeared beneath it—unmistakably human.

I had never heard of or seen an undead react this way. They had lost all sense and reason, driven solely by the instinct to slaughter.

What if—just maybe—his transformation into an undead isn't complete?

If that was true…what was I supposed to do?

Right now, a single blow would end the battle and allow me to console the souls of the victims.

But what would I be killing? A hero who had given his life to protect others, or a Death Knight Lord who had led a monster army through countless massacres and acts of destruction?

"Fuck…"

My hesitation was brief.

There was no helping it. The die had been cast, and he and I had already crossed the point of no return. He wasn't an opponent I could subdue with half measures. I had to end this now.

Rest easy.

Lei Fei. Death Knight Lord. Whoever he was, he would finally find peace.

My Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, unleashed at full power at the eighth level, would end it without pain.

Fwoosh! Whoooooosh!

My fist, engulfed in blue flames, shot forward to bring everything to an end.

At that moment—

—My. Lord!

A chilling voice slipped between dark-red lips. The flickering glow in his eyes suddenly steadied, and tangible mana erupted from him.

Crackle! KRAAAANG!

Flames and darkness collided.

The two tremendous forces crashed into each other and exploded in an enormous shock wave.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The deafening blast left my ears ringing. The tremendous recoil hurled me backward, but I flipped in midair and righted myself.

The ground and the monster remains caught in the explosion had been blown to pieces.

Through the pale smoke blanketing the devastated area for hundreds of meters[1930], a being wrapped in darkness approached.

—I am that person's most loyal servant.

Sssssss.

Darkness rose from the ruined earth—the death energy held within the fallen monsters.

—I am the supreme commander who leads the legion of the dead.

Whoooooosh!

The swirling darkness rushed toward him and was drawn into his body. His half-destroyed armor repaired itself, his broken bones rejoined, and the red glow in his eyes blazed fiercely.

As he recovered, his power grew.

Now filled with even greater mana, the being slowly raised his sword.

—By my lord's command, I shall fulfill my duty.

He was wrong.

His duty had been to serve as humanity's shield and guardian. But the hero who had given his life for others had lost his memories and been corrupted by the Arch Lich.

[1930] Hundreds of meters is roughly 200–900 m, or about 660–2,950 ft.

SYSTEM

Lv. 140 Death Knight Lord

Lei Fei no longer existed.

The being approaching me was nothing but a monster.

In that case…

“I have a duty to fulfill too.”

The instant I murmured those words—

Whoosh!

A sword shedding mana came down toward my head.

Slash!

One handspan[1931].

That was the distance by which death missed me.

Mana honed sharper than ever grazed my arm and sliced into the ground. There was no deafening crash, no spray of debris. More than ten meters[1932] of earth simply split apart like cheesecake.

Slice!

At the chilling sound, I thrust out my hand.

The searing heat of the Flame Divine Palm collided with the blade, which had already changed course.

KRAANG!

A tremendous shock wave exploded outward from between us. Through the swirling dust, I saw the red glow of his eyes burning brightly.

“Eat this.”

—…!

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist shot forward like a cannonball.

The bastard’s eyes flew wide as he drove his knee upward. My flame-wreathed fist collided with his knee, wrapped in darkness.

KRAAANG!

The world shook.

The tremendous recoil hurled me backward, and the outer wall of a building rapidly filled my vision.

I twisted my body in midair. The tips of my feet touched solid concrete.

[1931] A handspan is the distance across an outstretched hand, roughly 20 cm (8 in), though it varies by person.

[1932] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

Flamefire Path.

I channeled internal energy into both legs.

Concentrate.

Explode.

Crack. Boom!

The outer wall received all the force and speed loaded into my toes and burst apart.

I shot forward like a streak of flame. The Death Knight Lord was only just regaining his balance when I appeared in the air above his head.

Inventory open. Summon.

A sturdy spear shaft filled my hand. The energy coursing through my body surged down to my fingertips and into the spearhead.

Blue hellfire bloomed in midair, becoming a fire dragon's claw as it slashed downward.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, Second Form.

Heavenly Strike.

Whooooooooom—

Ultra-high heat burned the air.

The Death Knight Lord raised his sword toward the spear plunging down like a lightning bolt, his mana swelling as if about to detonate.

KRAANG!

The spearhead shattered, and a blue-black flash filled my vision.

Cracks spread like a spiderweb around the bastard, who had taken the full force carried by the spearhead. The next moment, the ground within a radius of more than a hundred meters[1933] sank inward.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The collapse opened a gigantic sinkhole.

Monsters caught in the aftermath of the battle shrieked as they plunged hundreds of meters[1934] into the depths.

The Death Knight Lord used a falling ogre as a foothold and shot back toward the surface. Then he looked up at me.

At me, standing high in the sky.

Stepping on Empty Air.

Another supernatural feat granted only to those who had reached the Supreme Peak realm.

[1933] A hundred meters is about 330 ft.

[1934] Hundreds of meters is roughly 200–900 m, or about 660–2,950 ft.

Feeling the immense drain on my internal energy, I stepped on empty air and shot upward. Before my feet could touch the ground, mana lashed toward my side like a whip.

Inventory open. Summon.

Clang!

I managed to block the attack, but the spearhead shattered into countless fragments.

White Flame had already been hurled away as a javelin. Even if the weapons stored in my inventory were of usable quality, in a battle like this they were nothing more than disposable weapons.

But the story changed when I had dozens—hundreds—of them.

Inventory open. Summon.

Whoooooosh! Clang!

Summon.

Crack!

With every exchange of blows, a spear shaft bent and a spearhead broke.

I didn't care.

Every sense in my body was honed to a silent edge, telling me exactly what was happening and what would come next.

Summon. Summon.

I crossed the spears in my hands and swung them like streaks of light.

Crack!

One shattered against his sword, but the other slammed into his side.

Boom!

As the earth-shaking impact drove him backward, I stepped forward.

One step.

That was all it took to appear before the Death Knight Lord. I advanced faster than he could retreat.

Blazing Flame Divine Spear, First Form.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Whoooooosh! Thrust!

A new spear, already drawn from my inventory, pierced the pitch-black armor and drove into the area around his knee.

The restored armor was tougher than before, but even the mana it had absorbed could not stop the Force coating the spearhead.

He can't feel pain, but he should still feel the impact.

Contrary to my expectations, however, the Death Knight Lord did not waver.

Slice!

He severed the spear with his mana-coated sword. Instead of retreating, he charged straight at me.

Slash!

Space split open, and every hair on my body stood on end.

I thought I had turned my head in time, but a thread-thin streak of mana grazed beneath my earlobe and sliced halfway through it.

Ssshhh!

Blood spurted from the wound along with a sharp, stinging pain.

Feeling it run down my neck, I thrust my palm toward his face.

Flames surged, and the Flame Divine Palm was about to erupt—

KRAANG!

My eyes widened amid the resounding boom.

The palm that should have blown his head off had been stopped by a pitch-black gauntlet.

What the hell?

I wasn't surprised that he had blocked the attack.

The Death Knight Lord's movement was still clumsy, but what he had just used was a type of palm technique I recognized.

More specifically, it had taken the form of the Flame Divine Palm.

This bastard…he's copying my martial arts.

As I stared into his unwavering red eyes, a thought flashed through my mind.

An S-rank Hunter secretly trained by China.

I had forgotten for a moment.

The being before me, now reduced to a monster, had once been a genius chosen from among 1.2 billion people—a secret weapon China had intended to keep hidden until the very end.

Impressive. Truly impressive.

I admired him inwardly.

At the same time, I became certain of one thing.

You can't beat me.

If he was the man chosen from among 1.2 billion people, then I was one of a kind among nearly seven billion.

The blood I had spilled traveling between the modern world and Murim, and my countless brushes with death, had made me who I was.

"Let's…end this."

I stepped forward as the quiet words left my mouth.

My mind was calmer than ever, and my five senses were razor-sharp.

Fwit!

I tilted my head, and the mana the Death Knight Lord unleashed in an explosive burst narrowly missed me.

Feeling the Scorching Yang Qi filling my entire body, I drove out my fist.

KRAANG!

An earth-shaking boom rang out, and his body shuddered.

He hurriedly tried to block by imitating a grappling technique, but the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist broke through his clumsy defense and slammed into his chest.

More.

Whoosh, boom!

More. More. More.

I repeated the words in my head as my hands and feet struck without pause.

Every blow laden with Force crashed against his sword or found an opening, battering him without end.

And it wasn't only the spears summoned from my inventory.

My fists, legs, elbows—everything that made up my body was both weapon and shield.

Crack! Slice!

His wrist was severed along with the gauntlet, and the once-mighty mana flickered like a candle flame.

The Death Knight Lord's armor slowly disintegrated, unable to withstand my physical power, which far surpassed human limits, and my internal energy, vast as the sea.

KRAANG!

We each struck without bothering to defend.

A System notification informed me that the Fire Dragon Armor's durability had fallen, while the armor covering his body shattered like glass.

Clatter.

His bare flesh was finally exposed.

Dark patches of lividity mottled his pale skin.

The red glow in the dead man's eyes flared more fiercely than ever, as though heralding the end.

—I am, I am…!

But his cry went unfinished.

Thrust!

A translucent spearhead punched through his pale skin and burst from his chest.

I had pulled White Flame back to me with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space.

Looking at him, I answered.

“That’s enough…rest now.”

Chapter 402

Thrust!

What is this?

It was hot, yet cool.

Sensing those two contradictory sensations, the Black Knight looked down at the transparent spearhead protruding through his chest.

He slowly raised his head. His gaze settled on the young human before him, whose expression he could not read.

“Enough…rest now.”

There was neither mockery for the defeated nor a victor’s joy in his voice. It sounded bitter and, in a way, wistful.

Those words filled the Black Knight’s mind.

Rest.

Then, in the next moment—

Crack!

The Black Knight heard everything binding him shatter.

The jet-black armor that had barely retained its shape broke into hundreds, then thousands of fragments, and the mighty mana within him faltered.

But the greatest change was taking place inside his mind.

That’s…

In a world that had slowed to a crawl, he saw a small, worn child’s shoe through the scattering fragments of armor.

At the same time, countless memories flashed through his mind.

“I want to become a Hunter.”

A young boy speaking of his dream.

“I’m proud of you. Thank you for growing up so well.”

“Thank you, Uncle. No…Father.”

A young man who had become both a proud nephew and a son.

“Is anyone there?”

“Welcome!”

…Ah.

On a day when everything had been perfect—the scent, the temperature, the weather—a man met a woman and fell in love.

“Will you marry me?”

The young boy who had wanted to become a Hunter became someone’s husband.

“Waaah! Waaah!”

“T-This child…”

“Congratulations on becoming a father, honey.”

At last, he became the father of a child.

“Dada! Momma!”

“Hahaha! That’s right! We’re your daddy and mommy!”

How could he ever forget those moments, when he had been happier than anyone else in the world?

A single tear rolled down his bloodless, pale cheek.

It swept away the dark clouds filling his mind. It was the tear of a dead man who had finally remembered who he was.

Ah…ahhh…

Only now did he know. Only now did he understand.

He reached out and grabbed the small shoe.

The nameless child crying in its parents’ arms overlapped with the image of his daughter smiling brightly as she saw him off on the morning he died.

“Daddy! Come back soon!”

“Have a safe trip. Be careful.”

He seemed to remember kissing his wife on the forehead and rubbing his face against his daughter’s cheek. He had hugged her as she laughed and complained that his beard was scratchy, then walked out the front door.

Leaving behind the same words he always did.

“I’ll be back.”

But he never kept that promise.

A few hours later, a disaster unlike any seen since the Great Cataclysm began. He fought with every ounce of strength he possessed until, at last, he came face-to-face with a certain being.

“How noble. Human, what is your name?”

“I am…”

The red glow burning in his eyes vanished as if it had been washed away.

The man with cloudy, gray-white eyes was no longer the Black Knight or the Death Knight Lord.

“Lei Fei. That is my name.”

Freed from his long darkness, he raised his head.

The setting sun shining through the clouds cast a reddish hue over his pale skin.

The System notification rang out just as I reached forward to deliver the final blow.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Information about the target has changed.
The changed information is displayed through Qi Sense.
Lv. 120 Lei Fei

"…!"

The unexpected development stopped me cold.

The gray-white eyes of the Death Knight Lord—or rather, Lei Fei—slowly shifted from the sky toward me. The voice that slipped between his lips was hollow and lonely.

"It feels like I've just had a terrible nightmare. No, I almost wish it had been a nightmare."

I had never heard of or seen anything like this before. After staring at him in silence, I spoke.

"Have you come back to your senses?"

"Yes. Only now, at last."

Lei Fei looked down at his hands. They were pale and rotting, with parts of the flesh and bone missing after our fierce battle.

They were also soaked in red blood.

Human blood.

"What have I done?"

The man who had sacrificed his life for humanity had become the commander of a monster army and slaughtered humans.

I could not even begin to imagine how he felt after realizing that terrible truth.

"Lei Fei."

I wanted to tell him. *It wasn't your will. The Arch Lich's magic had seized control of your mind.*

But Lei Fei shook his head.

"You don't have to say it. I already know what you're trying to tell me. But…"

Lei Fei gestured toward his body and continued.

"I don't think I have much time left."

Everything he said was true. The tough undead body that neither steel nor bullets had been able to pierce was slowly—very slowly—falling apart.

And, paradoxically, what was sustaining Lei Fei now was the mana that still remained within his body.

"It's ridiculous. I became one of the undead and killed humans, yet I'm holding on with that very power."

After muttering hollowly, he spoke to me.

“May I ask one favor?”

“…Please, go ahead.”

I thought Lei Fei wanted Erasure. I assumed he wished to find rest and escape from all his pain.

But the words that slipped from his lips were nothing like what I expected.

“Help me fulfill my mission.”

“…!”

“I swore an oath on the day I became a Hunter. I swore that I would fight monsters until the moment my life ended. That oath still stands.”

Lei Fei had already fulfilled his mission. He had charged forward bravely and shattered magnificently.

When he fought humanity as the Death Knight Lord, he had been acting on the Arch Lich’s will, not his own.

And yet he wanted to fight again. Though his life had already ended, he stood tall once more and reaffirmed his mission.

That was why I had to ask.

“Why? Why go this far?”

Lei Fei smiled faintly.

“What a foolish question.”

“What?”

“Why did you come running here alone, knowing that countless monsters and dangers awaited you? Why am I trying to fight until the very end? What’s the difference?”

“…!”

“You already know the answer. That is all.”

I already knew the answer.

The moment I heard those words, a shiver ran down my spine.

Lei Fei looked at me as I stood speechless, then raised a hand and gestured around us.

The countless monsters still remaining on the battlefield were reflected in his eyes, which had already lost the light of life.

“This…will be my final battle.”

Schlk!

Lei Fei pulled White Flame from his chest and handed it to me, then raised his sword.

Instead of the dazzling aura blade that symbolized an S-rank Hunter, ominous dark mana coiled around the blade and surged upward.

But the one wielding that power was not the Death Knight Lord.

It was a Hunter burning through his final mission.

“I’d like to fight alongside them. But will they allow me?”

Anyone who heard those words without knowing the circumstances would have dismissed them as random nonsense.

But I understood what Lei Fei meant. Lowering White Flame’s spearhead at an angle, I answered.

“They’ll be glad. If they’re the people I know.”

“…You think the same way I do.”

A red light flickered in Lei Fei’s gray-white eyes.

The mana he had dragged forth with all his strength seeped across the battlefield. Then a thunderous cry burst from his lips.

“Public Security Armed Forces Department—!”

And in the next moment—

Rustle. Rattle, rattle.

At the call of the Death Knight Lord—or rather, the head of the Public Security Armed Forces Department—the hundreds of Hunters who had fallen across the battlefield rose to their feet. Returned from death, they gripped their weapons and assembled in one place.

Lei Fei and I stood at their head.

“You take the lead. The living must finish this fight.”

As though bewitched, I stepped forward.

The monster army, thrown into confusion by the unexpected turn of events, finally gathered with savage roars.

They came for the commander who had become their enemy.

And for me, standing at the front.

Step. Step.

I walked forward, slowly but firmly.

Tap. Tap-tap.

Then I gradually picked up speed.

Lei Fei and the hundreds of Public Security Armed Forces Department Hunters resurrected as undead followed behind me.

It did not take long for the ripples to become a wave and crash over the enemy.

And at the entrance to what would be our final battle, Lei Fei shouted at the top of his lungs.

“Wipe them all out!”

It was the same cry that had echoed through the footage.

The Five-Starred Red Flag—their symbol and their pride—shone in the setting sun upon their battered, filthy armor.

With my chest throbbing, I became a streak of light and shot toward the monsters.

Whooooooosh! KRA-DOOM!

Crunch!

How many had I brought down by now?

Hundreds? A thousand?

Slash! Boom!

I had no idea. Like a man possessed, I kept moving forward. I smashed, cut, stabbed, and blew apart everything that stood in my way.

Whooooooosh!

—Kuaaaargh!

—Kraaah!

Blue hellfire surged upward in pillars, and monsters engulfed in flames that would not go out screamed.

Then, when I could no longer hear anything, I suddenly stopped.

“Hah, huff.”

I was out of breath. My mouth felt rough and dry, as if I had chewed and swallowed a handful of sand.

The fatigue I had briefly forgotten came crashing back over me as I looked around.

Across the vast expanse of land, not a single monster remained standing.

Neither the ogres and Trolls that had bellowed their savage cries nor the Wyverns and Gargoyles that had circled overhead.

And…

Thud. Thump!

The Public Security Armed Forces Department Hunters resurrected as undead began to fall as well.

Having fulfilled their final mission, they collapsed one after another like puppets whose strings had been cut.

As I watched them with an emotion I could not put into words, I realized what their collapse meant.

“…Lei Fei!”

He sat in the middle of the silent battlefield. One arm had been severed and his side torn open, yet he waited for me with a peaceful expression.

“You came at just the right time.”

I did not know why, but those simple words made something surge up inside my chest.

We had not even known each other for ten years, yet a curse slipped from my lips before I could stop it.

"Damn it…"

"Don't swear so much. I saw you on television, and it seems to be a habit. Women won't like that, and it's not good for children's education."

Lei Fei let out a quiet laugh. He already knew who I was.

"Is that really the problem right now? There has to be some way…"

—There is no such way, you treacherous human.

The Skeleton Warlord's voice was deeper and more subdued than usual.

Lei Fei stared at him, eyes widening.

"A monster?"

—I am the commander. You are a foolish but somewhat remarkable human.

"A monster, then. I have no idea what's going on, but…yes, if you're Jin Taekyung, I'm sure you'll handle it somehow."

Lei Fei nodded and raised his head toward the sky. His slowly blinking gray-white eyes reflected the sky, now stained entirely red.

"Could you pass along one message?"

I did not ask the foolish question, *To whom?*

I already knew.

"Tell them I love them. And tell them I'm sorry I couldn't come home."

It was the final message a dead man left for his family.

My chest churning, I answered.

"…I will."

"Thank you. You're a good person."

Lei Fei smiled faintly and tapped my shoulder with his one remaining hand.

With a dry, crumbling sound, his fingers broke apart into dust. Soon, his arm, his leg, his chest…

At the very end, one last sentence slipped between his lips.

"Go west. End this war."

Whoooooosh.

The wind blew. The hero, reduced to a handful of dust, scattered into the air.

As I stared blankly at the sight, dozens of planes appeared in my field of vision, flying toward us in formation.

Chapter 403

The twenty-odd military transport planes and the fighter jets escorting them ran into trouble before they could even land.

“W-What the…”

“We can’t find a landing site!”

Below them lay a small city reduced entirely to ruins.

The buildings packed tightly together had collapsed like dominoes, and flames rose from here and there.

But what frightened the pilots most was the horrific sight visible even from far above.

Schoolyards, convenience stores, government offices… In a place where peaceful daily life had vanished, mountains of corpses and rivers of red blood filled the void.

A vision of hell painted by the monster army.

As the pilots trembled with indescribable terror at the lifeless ground below, a voice rang out.

“Land.”

“C-Commander-in-Chief, but…”

“No buts. You will land. That is an order.”

The pilot took one look at the middle-aged man’s stony face and realized he had no choice.

He was a soldier, and the man before him was the de facto commander-in-chief directing this war.

Disobeying General Wei Fenghu—the Minister of National Defense under the Central Military Commission and Chairman Xiao’s most trusted confidant—would have been madness.

Then Wei Fenghu spoke again, and the pilot decided that disobedience might actually be the less insane option.

“Head for the general hospital the Western Front has been using as its temporary headquarters.”

“What? But that’s…”

“According to the last communication we received, that was where the fiercest fighting took place. It may still be going on.”

“…”

“I know that as well as you do. We may already be too late. But we have to go. If even one person is still alive, we must help them and fight alongside them.”

Wei Fenghu continued, his eyes grave.

“Take the controls. And land first.”

It was extraordinary enough that the commander-in-chief had come all the way here himself. Now he was ordering his plane to land first. With monsters potentially still in the area, the risk was enormous.

Damn it.

The pilot squeezed his eyes shut and switched on the radio. His trembling voice soon spread across the communications network to every aircraft.

"VIP-777 to all aircraft. I repeat, VIP-777 to all aircraft…"

As he listened to his orders being relayed, Wei Fenghu slowly drew a deep breath.

The parachute strapped to his body in case of an emergency felt as heavy as a massive boulder.

Is it because this is my first real battle in more than thirty years? I'm trembling.

And Wei Fenghu was not the only one.

All four thousand Hunters aboard the twenty-odd military transports carried fears of their own.

Some probably wanted to run away that very instant. Others were suppressing their fear and desperately trying to stoke their will to fight.

No one knew who would die in the battle about to begin. Wei Fenghu was no exception. The reason he had risked coming to the fiercest part of the battlefield despite being the commander-in-chief was simple: the morale of his soldiers.

A commander who sends only his subordinates to their deaths has no right to command.

That had been Wei Fenghu's lifelong principle, and Lei Fei—his nephew and as good as a son to him—had respected him for it.

The sudden memory of that beloved face sent an ache through the old general's heart.

"…I miss you."

Wei Fenghu murmured quietly.

It had already been fifteen days since Lei Fei had gone missing. But he had not let go of hope. Neither had Lei Fei's wife and daughter, who had been moved to a safe place.

Today, I saw someone who reminded me of you.

A young man who was still only in his twenties. He had achieved an incredible military feat in a distant foreign land, and when he heard that the Western Front was in danger, he had left without hesitation.

He had even laughed while attempting a teleport with a survival rate of only ten percent.

"Ten percent sounds pretty good."

"It's probably a thousand times higher than the odds of crossing dimensions."

When Magic Johnson relayed those words, Wei Fenghu had immediately mobilized the command headquarters' forces and assembled the squadron.

He had been deeply moved by the courage shown by Jin Taekyung, a young foreigner, and the sight of him had brought his missing nephew to mind.

You would have done the same, wouldn't you?

Just as Wei Fenghu's lips curved into a faint smile after asking the silent question, a cry rang out.

"H-How can this be…!"

"C-Commander-in-Chief!"

Wei Fenghu raised his head at their urgent shouts and looked out the window.

As the ground drew closer, a sea of corpses and blood came into view, more horrific than any battlefield he had ever witnessed.

Corpses and blood. Blood and corpses…

The general hospital serving as the Western Front's temporary headquarters lay in ruins, its twisted steel framework exposed. A gigantic sinkhole gaped like the entrance to hell, and dozens of craters carved into the ground brimmed with red and green blood.

Monster and human corpses lay tangled together in numbers too vast to count.

Thousands?

No. Well over ten thousand.

"My God…"

"W-Who did this?"

A land of death raked by disaster.

The pilots stared speechlessly at the devastated ground until Wei Fenghu's shout jolted them back to their senses.

"Lower our altitude! Quickly!"

"Yes, sir!"

The threat from the monsters had vanished, but they could not afford to let their guard down.

The pilot maneuvered the aircraft more carefully than ever, his entire body drenched in cold sweat as he attempted the landing.

Krrrrrrk, boom!

The aircraft shuddered violently several times. At last, when the transport successfully landed, the first person to step out was none other than Wei Fenghu.

Tat-tat-tat!

The two hundred Hunters aboard the transport quickly poured out behind him.

Their reactions fell into two categories.

"This is fucking insane…"

Shock at a sight beyond anything they had imagined.

"Urk… Urrrgh!"

Nausea from the stench of blood filling the air and the dismembered corpses strewn everywhere.

And through it all, one question filled every mind.

Who did this?

They had even forgotten they were supposed to search for survivors. Wei Fenghu and everyone else stood frozen like statues.

Then—

Splash. Splash.

Footsteps echoed across the silent battlefield.

Two hundred pairs of eyes turned toward a lone figure crossing the field, wading through pools of blood.

The man was drenched in green blood from head to toe. Wei Fenghu stared at him and groaned out a name.

"Mr. Jin…?"

It was definitely him.

Though he looked like a man made of blood, Wei Fenghu recognized him.

Jin Taekyung had survived a Teleport spell with only a ten-percent survival rate, overturned a hopeless battle, and lived.

His seemingly endless steps finally came to a halt before Wei Fenghu.

Splash.

Jin Taekyung brushed back the hair clotted together with the monsters' sticky blood. After a long silence, he spoke his first words.

"The battle is over. There are… no monsters left alive."

"…!"

"…!"

That unbelievable declaration sent a shudder through everyone present.

According to the Western Front's final transmission, the monster army had numbered a staggering ten thousand.

And that was not all. A Death Knight Lord believed to be one of the Arch Lich's closest servants had personally entered the battle, making this the most overwhelming offensive of the five fronts.

By contrast, barely a thousand Hunters had stood against them. The remaining People's Liberation Army troops might as well have been made of paper.

Not only did he win that battle—he annihilated a monster army of ten thousand.

It was a battle that would have been impossible without one man.

And a victory made possible because that one man had been there.

An S-rank Hunter was said to be a strategic weapon capable of overturning an entire battlefield in an instant. But since the Great Cataclysm, who had ever accomplished something like this?

The two hundred Hunters gazed at the young man before them in awe.

But Wei Fenghu was different.

The old general stared at Jin Taekyung with grief and fear in his eyes.

No—not at Jin Taekyung himself.

At the sword in his hand.

Wei Fenghu knew that sword all too well, which only made the pain in his heart worse.

He knew what its presence meant.

"Did you… meet him?"

After a brief silence, Jin Taekyung answered.

"He asked me to pass along his love."

"…!"

"He also said he was sorry."

Wei Fenghu clenched his teeth against the sob rising in his throat. Through his tear-clouded vision, he heard one final sentence.

"He was the best Hunter I've ever seen."

That was all.

Plip, plip. Tears rolled down Wei Fenghu's wrinkled face.

A breeze blew from somewhere and gently wrapped around him.

Rank, achievements, whether someone was a Hunter or not—none of it mattered.

The fact that he had sacrificed himself for someone else was enough to make him worthy of being called a hero.

That was why Lei Fei would remain in my memory for a long time.

A man resurrected as an undead who died as a human.

He had fulfilled his mission to the very end. He was a true Hunter and a true hero.

The countless others who had died here today were no different.

And neither were the two people who had yet to regain consciousness.

The healer said they wouldn't wake up until they'd recovered from their exhaustion.

Remembering what the healer who had stopped by earlier had told me, I looked at Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen, both sunk in a deep sleep.

Thanks to the Top-Grade Potion, their injuries had vanished as if they had never existed. But the fatigue accumulated in their bodies and minds was a separate matter.

Even I occasionally pass out, and I level up.

The two of them had fought bravely to the very end.

They had held on to their weapons even while enduring the pain of having their limbs severed.

“Heroes… heroes, huh.”

I muttered under my breath and looked at the sword lying beside me.

The sword left behind by that very hero. His keepsake.

Wei Fenghu had wept without end as he returned it to me despite my repeated refusal.

“He would have wanted you to keep it too, Mr. Jin.”

Really, Lei Fei?

I ran my fingers over the blade as I asked a question that would never receive an answer.

It was a magnificent sword, its chilling edge apparent at a glance.

Item appraisal.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Hero’s Soul
Type: Sword
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Those worthy of being called heroes
Description: Extremely hard and sharp. The final soul of a noble hero dwells within it, and those who meet its qualifications can draw out even greater power.

Hero’s Soul?

It was a fitting name for Lei Fei, but the sword was certainly strange.

Its Supreme Peak Grade made sense, considering it had survived that fierce battle without so much as a hairline crack. The restriction, however, was unique.

Only someone with an upright character can use it?

Hmm. Might as well put it to the test.

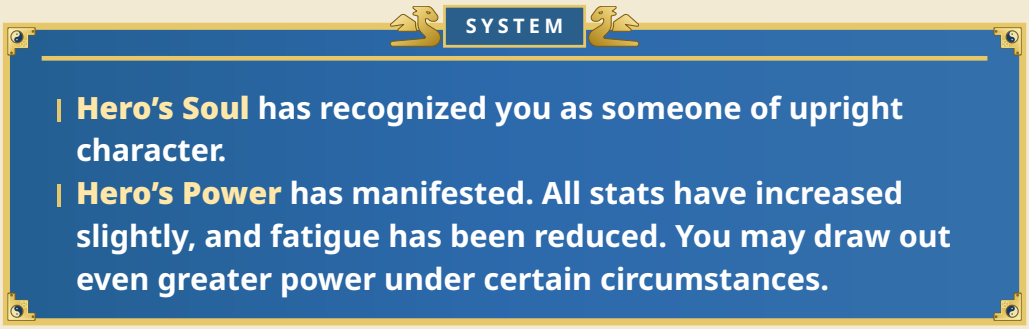
Without hesitation, I gripped the hilt and slashed downward through the air.

Whoosh!

Better than I expected.

The weight and balance were perfect, and I liked how its edge seemed sharp enough to split the wind itself. The System notification that immediately followed was the icing on the cake.

Ding.



I had no idea what those certain circumstances were, but apparently this wasn't one of them. The increase in my stats was so tiny I couldn't feel it at all.

It was like adding a single bucket of water to a lake.

Still, it would be perfect for judging someone's character.

A character-testing sword.

From now on, I would test everyone who approached me with Hero's Soul. If the sword accepted them, I'd keep them close. If it didn't, I'd cut them down, root and branch—snip…

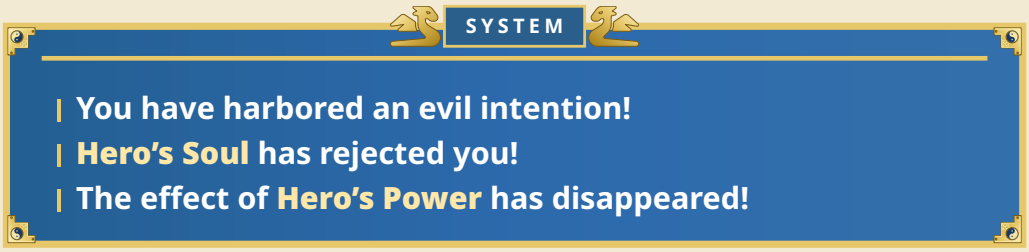
Crackle!

A powerful electric current suddenly shot through my hand, and I dropped the sword.

"What the hell?"

As bewilderment washed over me, a sharp alarm sounded and a System message appeared in the air.

Beep!



"…"

Come on. It was just a passing thought.

I looked down at the fallen sword and let out a short laugh. It suddenly occurred to me that perhaps a little of Lei Fei's soul really did linger within it.

Wait. If that was true…

"Are you listening?"

After a brief silence, the Skeleton Warlord, currently stored inside my Inventory, answered.

"…I am."

"I wanted to ask you something."

"…If your question concerns whether that sword is an Ego Sword, the answer is no. Only the faintest trace of a soul remains within it. The human you are thinking of has already ceased to exist."

He usually had a screw loose, but he was still a Named Monster and the commander of an army of the dead.

He had absorbed some of the magical power scattered during Lei Fei's Erasure and grown even stronger, so there was a good chance he was right.

That aside…

"Is something wrong?"

"Hmm?"

"You've seemed gloomy for a while."

Even as I said it, I wondered if the question made any sense. Why was I asking an undead monster why he seemed gloomy? Weren't they gloomy by nature?

The problem is, he doesn't usually act like this.

But then the Skeleton Warlord suddenly spoke.

"A thought occurred to me."

"What thought?"

"What kind of being was I in the past?"

"…!"

"I have no memories at all. Although the human named Lei Fei has ceased to exist, this commander was secretly envious of him. At least he learned who he was."

I hadn't expected him to be thinking about something like that.

After considering it for a moment, I spoke in a warm voice.

"Then should I erase you too?"

"…!"

"What? You said you were envious."

"N-No, that isn't what I meant…"

The Skeleton Warlord's frantic explanation was cut short by a knock and a polite voice from beyond the door.

"Mr. Jin. Comrade Minister of State would like to see you."

It seemed it was already time.

"Yes. I'll be right there."

I took one last look at the two sleeping figures, then rose from my seat. As I did, I murmured the words I hadn't managed to say earlier.

"Well, if you ask me, you were probably a pretty decent guy."

"…Huh? Were you talking to this commander?"

"No. Just talking to myself."

“Ahem. Right?”

But the sudden brightness in the Skeleton Warlord’s previously dejected voice was definitely not my imagination.

I let out a quiet laugh and left the room.

Chapter 404

“Whew.”

Night had fallen, pitch-black.

The moment he returned, the young man threw off his equipment and dropped heavily into a seat. As he struggled to catch his breath, a middle-aged man approached and handed him a drink.

“You look exhausted. Drink this.”

The two men had bonded somewhat on the way here over their shared status as Hunters drafted from Shanxi Province.

The young man recognized the familiar face and eyed the can in the middle-aged man’s hand, then muttered dubiously.

“Did this come from the supplies? I don’t think I’ve seen this drink before.”

“It came in with the foreign relief supplies. It’s not from our country.”

“Hmm. Got anything carbonated?”

“If you don’t want it, forget it.”

The middle-aged man began to withdraw his hand, but the young man quickly grabbed it and spoke with a solemn expression.

“Sir. Have I ever told you that canned ration drinks are my favorite thing in the world?”

“No.”

“Then you’re about to learn.”

“Good. That’s the spirit.”

“I’ll enjoy it.”

Click.

The young man opened the can and took a sip. His expression changed subtly, but before he could say anything, the middle-aged man asked him a question.

“You’re coming back from searching Sector Three, aren’t you?”

“…Urk. Yes.”

“Must’ve been rough.”

The young man answered with a shrug. His bare upper body was drenched in cold sweat that had yet to dry, and green blood was splattered across his cheek.

“Monster blood. Did you get into a fight?”

“No. I was passing a building when a damn Gargoyle corpse fell. Must’ve been caught on the roof.”

“That must’ve caused quite a commotion.”

“Do you even have to ask? The rookies with only a year or two under their belts started puking and pissing themselves the moment they got covered in blood.”

"And you?"

"I may not look it, but I've been a Hunter for seven years. I didn't even blink."

The middle-aged man's gaze slowly drifted toward a particular part of the young man's body. He stared at the faint stain on his navy-blue pants, then nodded.

"Hmm. I see."

"…It's sweat."

"I didn't say anything. But looking at you is somehow making my eyes sweat."

"…Actually, I did piss a little. Is it obvious?"

"Yep."

"Damn it."

The middle-aged man silently watched him swear and tip back the can, then abruptly asked, "Did you find any survivors?"

"…!"

"So it was the same on your side."

The young man's expression stiffened the instant the words left the man's mouth. The middle-aged man let out a sigh.

He had already taken part in one search himself.

It had been a truly nightmarish experience.

Everywhere he looked, bodies torn apart by monsters lay piled high, and the horrific stench made his head feel as if it would split open.

Neither of them would ever forget what they had seen that day.

"…I can't even imagine how fierce the battle must've been."

"You don't need to. Whatever you imagine, it was worse."

The four thousand Hunters who had come here with Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu had been divided according to their units and sent to search the small city. Every piece of search equipment they used kept producing the same result.

No survivors.

Aside from the three thousand People's Liberation Army soldiers who had fled in terror at the start of the battle, everyone lay cold and dead. No one yet knew how many of the cowardly deserters scattered across the region had survived.

"At this rate, we can't even call it a casualty count. A death toll would be more accurate…"

"Watch what you say. We don't know that yet."

"Mm. I'm sorry. I spoke carelessly."

"As long as you understand. And…"

The middle-aged man cut off the young man's thoughtless remark and continued.

"Casualty count is the right term. There are survivors."

"…Oh."

The young man remembered the three people he had momentarily forgotten—the three who had survived this gruesome hell.

“You mean the regimental commander of the Public Security Armed Forces Department? That young fellow?”

“That’s right. The young man from Korea survived too.”

“And then there’s…”

The first two had certainly acted heroically, but compared to the last survivor, they were no more than fireflies before the sun.

The young man swallowed hard, and the middle-aged man finished for him.

“Yes, that man. No—that person survived too.”

Unmistakable awe filled his voice. He felt no discomfort referring to someone far younger than himself as “that person,” because he knew just how extraordinary the man’s achievements had been.

“Can you believe it? That a single Hunter could be that strong?”

He was a seasoned Hunter himself. That meant he could at least vaguely imagine what sort of monsters S-rank Hunters were.

But Jin Taekyung’s feats had been so incredible that it was hard to believe they were the work of a Hunter—or even a human being.

“It was a monster army nearly ten thousand strong. There were two Death Knights, and even a Death Knight Lord said to be as strong as an S-rank Hunter, if not stronger.”

The middle-aged man rattled on, his voice brimming with excitement.

“And how many allied Hunters were there? A mere thousand. The People’s Liberation Army was there too, but even they…”

“Nearly half of them fled when the front line collapsed. The rest fought bravely, but the monsters slaughtered them. I heard about it too.”

“How many Hunters do you think were left when Jin Taekyung arrived? A thousand? No, I’d stake my life that fewer than half were still alive!”

Had he witnessed the situation when Jin Taekyung arrived, the shock might have sent him into cardiac arrest.

Even this man, who revered Jin so deeply, had never imagined that Jin Taekyung had faced the monster army alone.

“He led hundreds of exhausted, wounded Hunters and annihilated a monster army more than ten times their size! Do you think that makes any sense?”

The young man gave him a deeply skeptical look.

“I don’t think it does.”

“Exactly. But that person did it!”

“Uh, sir. Sorry to rain on your parade, but none of that has actually been confirmed yet, has it?”

"What?"

"I think Jin Taekyung…"

"Not Jin Taekyung. Mr. Jin!"

The middle-aged man's eyes bulged as he barked the correction. The young man flinched and cleared his throat.

"Ahem. I mean, I admit that Mr. Jin is incredibly strong, but I can't help thinking the story might be a little exaggerated."

"Exaggerated? You saw the marks left on the battlefield and you can still say that? If it wasn't Mr. Jin, then who…"

"Come on, don't get so worked up. Try looking at this objectively. If everything you're saying is true, then Mr. Jin is stronger than Faye Chen or Wu Heixing."

"I have no interest in ranking them, but judging by their accomplishments during this Monster Wave, Mr. Jin clearly comes first. So?"

"Faye Chen may be from Hong Kong, but she's a hero who accomplished countless great feats during the Great Cataclysm. And for all the trouble Wu Heixing causes, he's still a true genius born of Zhonghua.[1935] Jin Taekyung surpassing both of them? That crosses the line."

The middle-aged man stared at him with equal parts disbelief and contempt.

"You're the one who crossed the line."

"What?"

"Is that really all you have to say? You shout that Zhonghua is number one, then belittle the hero who won us a great victory and saved our people?"

The young man's face twisted.

"Since you brought it up, Jin Taekyung only saved two people today. No, one of them was Korean, so he only saved one of our people. And that man was perfectly fine, without a single wound. He fought to protect his own countrymen, that's all. You don't seriously think he used a Top-Grade Potion, do you?"

"There's no point talking to you. Instead of praising him, this is how you repay him? I wonder what Mr. Jin would say if he heard…"

The middle-aged man shook his head and rose from his seat.

At that moment, a voice spoke behind them.

"Maybe he would've said you were a fucking asshole who wasn't worth helping."

"…!"

"…!"

The two men spun around in shock at the voice that had approached without a sound.

Before them stood a man whose face they knew well from television and the media.

[1935] *Zhonghua* is a literary and patriotic term for China and Chinese civilization.

“Hic.”

The young man stared up at someone a full head taller than him and began to hiccup.

“J-J-J-J-J-Jin!”

The middle-aged man stuttered as though he were buffering.

Jin Taekyung regarded the two of them with a friendly smile.

“Young man, stop hiccupping unless you want to become a good Chinese person. And you, sir, stop the earthquake—unless you’re planning to bring down the Arch Lich with a massive one.”

“Hic—gulp.”

“A-Are you really him?”

Jin Taekyung nodded slightly.

“I was going to keep walking, but then I heard something particularly irritating.”

“…Th-That…”

Jin Taekyung turned to the source of that irritating noise, who had stopped hiccupping and begun trembling like a leaf.

“How old are you?”

“I-I’m twenty-nine.”

“You’re older than me. I’ll speak casually.”

“…What?”

“What?”

“N-Nothing.”

The young man had no grounds to complain even if Jin Taekyung cursed him out, let alone spoke casually to him.

He had only ever seen Jin Taekyung from a distance or in passing. Now that he realized Jin had heard everything he had said, his hands and feet began to tingle, and his vision went white.

“I-I’m sorry.”

“You don’t need to apologize. That’s how talking behind someone’s back works. I understand.”

“Th-Thank you.”

Just as Jin Taekyung’s gentle smile began to melt the young man’s heart, he continued.

“Nothing to thank me for. Talking shit is fun while you’re doing it, but when you get caught, you’re fucked.”

“…!”

“There should be someone behind me right now. See him?”

Slowly—very slowly—the young man shifted his gaze.

Sure enough, a little over ten meters[1936] away, a middle-aged man with the face of a demon was radiating a terrifying aura in his direction.

"They say he's an A-rank Hunter with the Central Military Commission. He must have found your story very interesting, because he keeps bowing to me. Run over and put a pain-relief patch on him."

"Y-Yes, sir!"

The young man answered with a shriek and dashed over, only to let out a real scream when a mana-infused kick caught him in the shin.

Jin Taekyung laughed quietly at the sight and started to leave, then suddenly stopped.

"Ah, there's one thing you're mistaken about."

"M-Me?"

The middle-aged man, still half-dazed, snapped back to his senses.

"I'm sorry, but what would that be?"

"I didn't do it alone."

"What?"

"Everyone fought like hell. By the time I got there, the battle was almost over. Make sure you tell the others that too."

"Is that really true?"

"Of course. Oh, do you have a family?"

"Yes. Three daughters and five sons…"

"You're quite the patriot. In a few years, you'll have enough for a soccer team."

Jin Taekyung thought for a moment, then abruptly asked, "You're not assigned to a combat unit, are you?"

"…You could tell right away."

The middle-aged man lowered his head in embarrassment.

"As you can see, I'm an E-rank Hunter, so I was excluded from combat. I'll probably be assigned to tally the casualties."

"Then could I ask you one favor?"

"It would be my honor, Mr. Jin."

"Please add one person to the list of the dead. You won't find his body, so I'm asking you to make a special exception."

"What is his name?"

"Lei Fei. Lei Fei."

Those were Jin Taekyung's final words to him.

The middle-aged man remained rooted in place, staring after Jin for a long time before finally releasing the breath he had been holding.

[1936] A little over ten meters is a little over 33 feet.

He felt certain that Jin Taekyung's expression the last time he saw him would remain etched in his memory for a long time.

What was that look in his eyes…?

The resolve to see something through, no matter what.

The middle-aged man, who had been singing Jin Taekyung's praises moments before, picked up the can the young man had left behind and took a swallow to wet his throat.

Then he grimaced at its indescribable flavor.

"Ptooey!"

Burdian?

It seemed to be a Korean drink, but it tasted god-awful.

"You're here, Mr. Jin."

Wei Fenghu was not the only one waiting for me.

Five monitors stood inside the conference room, each displaying a seated S-rank Hunter.

I spoke calmly.

"Let's go end this war."

At long last, it was time to eliminate the culprit behind all of this.

Chapter 405

"The operation will commence tomorrow at 06:30. Every front is to carry out its assigned orders without fail."

Pop.

With those final words from Wei Fenghu, the Minister of National Defense, the meeting ended.

Lee Jungryong, Vice Guild Master of Ares Guild, leaned back in his chair and stared at the five monitors that had gone dark.

Things are moving quickly. Far more quickly than I expected.

This was not a war that would end easily, nor was it a war that should end so easily.

China was both a Hunter powerhouse with an enormous number of Hunters and a closed-off country. It was also one of the few countries where Ares Guild, which had extended its reach across the world through its mercenary business, had failed to establish a proper foothold.

That was why Lee Jungryong did not want China to remain stable. The more damage China suffered, the wider the cracks he could exploit.

More than a million casualties? Hundreds of trillions of won[1937] in property damage?

What did any of that matter? This Monster Wave might have been a disaster for some, but for Lee Jungryong, it was an opportunity.

But…

Once again, Jin Taekyung is the problem.

Lee Jungryong raised a finger and slowly tapped the table.

He had always known that the world did not move according to plan, but lately, whenever Jin Taekyung blocked his path at every turn, the same thought kept surfacing.

He's dangerous.

The interest Lee Jungryong had felt when he first learned of Jin Taekyung's existence had long since vanished without a trace.

If a child who had barely reached an adult's waist suddenly shot up within a few months and met that adult's gaze head-on, the adult could not help but be unsettled.

And what if the child was still growing?

He'll only become more dangerous.

If the Arch Lich's rampage had been an opportunity for Lee Jungryong, it had given Jin Taekyung wings.

[1937] Roughly 100–900 trillion won is about $71–640 billion or €65–580 billion.

The man had achieved incredible feats in battle and now stood in the global spotlight.

Another war had produced a new hero, just like the heroes born amid the chaos of the Great Cataclysm.

People fear the strong even as they envy them, but heroes are worshiped.

Lee Jungryong knew that better than anyone. And if this war ended because of Jin Taekyung's exploits—if that happened—then…

Crack.

The tip of his finger, infused with aura, had already bored through the solid wood and reduced it to powder.

Lee Jungryong silently looked down at the table, its center punched clean through.

For now, it was only a small hole. But if it continued to grow, it would soon become impossible to control. He had to fill it before the table collapsed.

"Send in the Head of Security."

At Lee Jungryong's quiet order, someone waiting outside the door left to carry it out.

Before long, the door opened and a familiar figure stepped inside.

"You called for me?"

Jin Taekyung was not the only one who had changed in such a short time.

Go Jun, Lee Jungryong's right hand and Head of Security, had changed a great deal as well.

A dark light lay deep in his eyes, and his voice had grown dry. A few people who knew the circumstances whispered that after losing to Jin Taekyung, his already hard expression had turned even gloomier.

Lee Jungryong disagreed.

"You look well."

"I've made a little progress."

"Too much modesty is unbecoming. You accomplished a great deal on today's battlefield as well. You deserve the praise."

"…Thank you."

The monster army's sudden assault on five fronts had left enormous casualties, but the northern front under Lee Jungryong's command had been the sole exception.

The Ares Guild elites, who had conserved their strength by hanging back in previous battles, slaughtered the monster army. Go Jun had also single-handedly killed two Death Knights that had served as the monsters' leaders.

"What were our losses?"

“Eleven severely injured and forty-six lightly injured. No deaths. The severely injured will need more time to recover, but the others have already been fully healed.”

The more than four thousand casualties among the other Hunters and soldiers did not enter their calculations.

Lee Jungryong asked, and Go Jun answered. To the two of them, only Ares Guild counted as allies.

“It’s unfortunate about the commander, though. To die such an untimely death. He was quite a tough man…”

As Lee Jungryong trailed off, a gloomy light flickered in the depths of Go Jun’s eyes.

“I’m sorry. I tried to stop them with everything I had, but there were simply too many monsters.”

“It couldn’t be helped. Did you recover the body?”

“It was too badly mangled, so we had no choice but to cremate him. The staff officers who died with him were treated the same way.”

“Well done. Ah, you know Lieutenant General Wang Ochun has been appointed the new commander, don’t you?”

“Yes. I was just on my way back from meeting him.”

Only a handful of people, including Lee Jungryong, knew that Lieutenant General Wang Ochun and Go Jun had met before.

For several years, the two had occasionally shared meals at secluded safe houses. Each time, the trunk of Lieutenant General Wang Ochun’s sedan grew heavier.

“What did he have to say?”

“He said he looked forward to working with me.”

A faint smile touched Lee Jungryong’s lips.

“Of course. You’re comrades who will be fighting together.”

By now, Wang Ochun was probably delighted to have been entrusted with such an important post. He had no idea that this entire chain of events was anything but simple good fortune.

Nor did he know that his tough predecessor, now reduced to a handful of ashes, had been preparing a report on Ares Guild’s lackluster performance in battle.

“Watch over him carefully. We can’t afford to lose our commander twice, can we?”

“Understood.”

Anything could happen on a battlefield.

A commander on poor terms with someone might be torn to pieces by monsters, while a corrupt general with a fondness for money might be appointed in his place.

Now in a considerably better mood, Lee Jungryong continued.

“You’ll have a hard time starting tomorrow, so get plenty of rest tonight.”

“What do you mean by that…?”

“We’ve been ordered to advance with all possible speed and sweep away the remaining monsters.”

“Mobile warfare, then. Was that order issued to every front?”

Lee Jungryong nodded.

Beginning tomorrow morning, the five fronts, including the northern front, would commence mobile warfare. Within a few days, they would cut off the monster army’s retreat and tighten an encirclement around it.

“They must have taken considerable losses as well, but their numbers will still be formidable.”

“What do you think this country has more of than anything else? Even now, hundreds of transport planes are carrying Hunters in from all across China. Even low-ranking Hunters will make useful arrow fodder.”

Lee Jungryong spoke calmly, then continued.

“Focus on minimizing the Guild’s losses. Just in case…”

His gaze deepened as it settled on the table.

“There may come a time when you have to fill a hole.”

“…I’ll keep that in mind.”

The meaning was unclear, but to Go Jun, Lee Jungryong was both a revered Master and as good as a god.

Without questioning him, Go Jun silently nodded. Then he suddenly realized that he had forgotten to ask something important.

“Where is our final destination?”

Instead of answering, Lee Jungryong raised a hand and pointed at the map of Sichuan Province that covered the wall.

Pshk!

A blast of wind shot from his fingertip and pierced one section of the map. Go Jun’s gaze fell on the place-name written beside the hole.

Suining City.

The place where this entire catastrophe had begun.

The Arch Lich was there.

At dawn the next day, everyone who woke found themselves divided into two groups.

Those who were leaving and those who were staying.

Naturally, I belonged to the former group, while Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen belonged to the latter.

Only when our departure was imminent did the two of them finally regain consciousness—and immediately start protesting the fact that they were being left behind.

"Mr. Jin. I'm perfectly fine."

"I'm perfectly fine, hyung[1938]!"

"I can fight."

"I'm confident I can fight harder than anyone!"

…What is this, an echo?

As I looked at Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen shouting with stiff expressions, I had no choice but to make them an offer.

"Hmm. If you can last ten minutes against me, I'll take you along."

"…"

"…"

"Is that what you call an offer, you shameless, wicked human?"

Shameless, my ass.

If anything, those two were the shameless ones. They could barely run properly, yet they wanted me to take them onto a battlefield.

It was good that they were burning with fighting spirit, but heading into battle in their current condition was a surefire way to get themselves killed.

And what kind of undead talks about conscience?

Why, I oughta…

After making that threat in my head, I addressed the two thoroughly dejected men.

"For now, focus on recovering. If you spend the next few days getting your feel back and your stamina returns, you might be deployed to the front then. That goes for you too, Shen—not just Team Leader Choi."

"Hmm."

"Hmmmm."

They still did not look happy, but at least they seemed somewhat resigned.

Both of them knew what condition their bodies were in. They could not keep insisting forever.

"Then I'd better get going… Ah."

I had forgotten something.

Pretending to rummage through my bag enchanted with space-expansion magic, I pulled out the item I had stored in my Inventory and held it toward Xiao Shen.

"Here."

Xiao Shen blinked.

[1938] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"…Hyung[1939]?"

"What are you waiting for? Take it. My arm's going to fall off."

Xiao Shen reflexively accepted it and stared at me in confusion.

"What is this?"

"A gift. Someone I know entrusted it to me, but I think you should have it."

"A sword this fine?"

"Why? You don't want it?"

"No, that's not it. I'm just not sure I should accept something like this…"

Xiao Shen hurriedly waved his hands, then gazed almost dreamily at Hero's Soul as he gripped its hilt.

Its weight distribution and balance were close to perfect, and the transparent blade gleamed with unmistakable sharpness.

He swallowed hard.

"Can I really accept this?"

"I'm not giving it to you for no reason. I'm giving it to you because you qualify."

"I qualify…?"

"That's right."

The courage he had shown in the last battle. His sacrifice for someone else.

That was enough.

Besides, I had been using a spear for years. If I kept the sword, it would only rot away in my Inventory.

Xiao Shen, another Chinese member of the Public Security Armed Forces Department, was a more fitting owner than I was.

And since nothing happened when he grabbed the hilt, I guess the sword has accepted him too.

The Skeleton Warlord grumbled quietly.

"This commander is good with a sword too… This commander likes swords…"

Huh? What was that?

It was hard to hear the words of a loser who had secretly grabbed Hero's Soul from my Inventory at dawn and screamed.

"…Hmph, forget it. A cheap sword like that is unworthy of this commander!"

"…"

What is he talking about? Someone who wants it more than you is sitting quietly right here.

Since I was thinking about it anyway, I discreetly glanced at Team Leader Choi.

[1939] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Truthfully, I had agonized until the very end over whether to give Hero’s Soul to Xiao Shen or Team Leader Choi.

Team Leader Choi was human too, after all. He might have felt hurt.

But apparently, all that concern had been for nothing.

“Congratulations, Regimental Commander Shen. That is truly an excellent sword.”

At Team Leader Choi’s sincere congratulations, Xiao Shen finally came to his senses and looked back and forth between him and Hero’s Soul.

Conflict flickered in his eyes, but a bright smile soon spread across his face.

“I don’t think I’m the one this sword belongs to.”

“…?”

“Mr. Choi, would you accept this sword in my place?”

I had not expected that.

Still…

That’s nice to see.

Team Leader Choi politely refused in his confusion, but Xiao Shen had already made up his mind, and his resolve proved stronger.

As I watched the two of them pass the sword back and forth, I quietly slipped out of the ward and started walking.

Before I closed the door, Team Leader Choi’s voice reached my ears.

“Of all the swords I’ve ever seen, I like this one the most.”

Right. Then that settled it.

I strode through the ranks of the troops who had already assembled.

The wall of people parted before me amid looks of awe.

Chapter 406

The age of the Great Cataclysm, which began with the descent of the Demon King Asmodeus, had been grim and chaotic. But humanity survived the crisis, swiftly repaired the damage, and built a civilization even more advanced than before.

Still, for some people, certain things mattered more than mana-stone elevators or healing potions.

“The internet got faster.”

The man who muttered those words in a reverent voice adjusted his glasses.

It was 11:30 a.m. Behind him, the ramen he had just dropped into the pot bubbled away, while cold rice and sour kimchi waited on the table.

Everything was ready. In exactly three minutes, he would add one—no, two—A-grade jumbo eggs he had agonized over buying during a supermarket sale. Then, after two more minutes, the perfect lunch would be complete.

And until then, the boredom would be solved by the marvelous modern civilization known as the smartphone.

“Let’s seeee, today’s news…”

Humming, the man skimmed the screen of his smartphone.

The main page of *Hunter University*, a massive online forum he frequented, had been updated with new top posts ranked by popularity.

1. **[Victory report after victory report—is the monster army already as good as shattered? The UN Security Council issues an official statement: “Humanity is strong. But the war is not over yet. We must not let our guard down until the very end.”]**
2. **[The Miracle of Sichuan Province. Jin Taekyung stood at the center of it all.]**
3. **[National prestige rises by the day as a new hero is born. K-pop and kimchi sales skyrocket.]**
4. **[Scheduled Korea–US summit to proceed… President Doramp makes a startling statement at an official event: “Is this Jin Taekyung’s country? He’s my idol.”]**
5. **[Ares Guild continues its string of victories. Truly living up to its reputation.]**
6. **[Chinese Chairman Xiao Yang: “Every one of them is a hero.”]**
7. **[Maesaeng-i.com Translation: Overseas netizens react to the current situation. “Who the hell is this ‘Lady of the House’[1940] Koreans keep killing every chance they get?”]**

[1940] *Jumo* is a traditional form of address for a tavern keeper or female host. Calling for the *jumo* is also a Korean online expression of excitement at a patriotic success; the headline’s imagined foreign commenter mistakes it for a person Koreans keep attacking.

8. **[Japanese Prime Minister Maigumi Shinjiro: “The Monster Wave must be handled in a Fun, Cool, and Sexy manner.” When a reporter asked what that meant, he grinned and replied, “Explaining it wouldn’t be sexy.”]**
9. **[Russian President Furin: “To me, Shinjiro is like quantum mechanics. No matter how much I look at him, I can’t understand him.”]**
10. **[Web-novel author becomes a prophet: exclusive interview with Zerobic. “How do I feel right now? I’m still stunned. Since we’re on the subject, I’ll be taking a break today.” During the interview, his enraged editor burst in and injured him badly enough to require twelve weeks of treatment, resulting in an unexpected hiatus. Though bleeding, Zerobic smiled and said he was happy to be able to rest. His editor, Mr. Lee, wept. “He isn’t human.”]**

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“Wow. This place is going absolutely nuts. Absolutely nuts.”

A smile tugged at the muttering man’s lips. No matter how far he scrolled, everything was about Jin Taekyung.

There seemed to be a few strange articles mixed in here and there, but simply reading them filled him with pride.

The comment section was already on the verge of exploding.

> ㄴThe activity here is insane lately. I’ve been on Hunter University since elementary school, but I’ve never seen it this heated before;; ㄴThe truly insane one is Jin Taekyung. He carved through a monster army ten thousand strong all by himself. It still makes no sense when I think about it. How the hell did he do that? ㄴHe’s amazing, but let’s get the facts straight. It wasn’t ten thousand, just a few thousand. ㄴLMAOOOO isn’t that still completely insane? ㄴFor real□□□□[1941] You’re the kind of bastard who’d get a goblin’s poison stinger in the ass and yell, “Ow, please let go gently!” Aren’t you the same guy who used an aura blade with your keyboard last time?

> ㄴBut at this point, Jin Taekyung doesn’t seem like an ordinary S-rank Hunter. Are all the other S-rank Hunters like that too? ㄴEven during the Great Cataclysm, feats on this level were rare. Cheon Taemin doesn’t count because he was just on another level entirely… But if you look at the records from the Great Cataclysm, Lee Jungryong probably accomplished something similar too. ㄴHmm. So he still isn’t at Lee Jungryong’s level? Disappointing.

[1941] □□ represents laughter in Korean online chat.

> ㄴ?? Do you think Lee Jungryong is some old man hanging around a spring on the neighborhood hill? Cheon Taemin may have overshadowed him, but judging by his achievements, martial power, and influence, he's still one of the top figures in the entire world. ㄴ 222.[1942] You only have to look at what happened a week ago. He wiped out the monster army with the fewest casualties across all five fronts. Jin Taekyung is incredible, but Lee Jungryong and Ares Guild are fucking amazing too. The northern front is actually advancing a little faster right now. ㄴ Comments like this make me nervous for no reason. I'm worried that a bunch of idiots will show up again and start going wild with the versus arguments. ㄴ They've been IP-banned to hell, so it should be fine. But at this point, isn't the whole incident basically over? They're crushing the monsters with mobile warfare right now. ㄴ Undefeated for an entire week □□□;[1943] ㄴ The Arch Lich must be panicking too. He put everything into that surprise attack a week ago and still got completely wrecked. The Death Knight Lord is dead, and the survivors who ran away are being harvested right now. They're screwed.

> ㄴ At this point, shouldn't the Arch Lich be making a move? He's so quiet that it feels strange. ㄴ I had the same thought, so I sent him a KakaoTalk[1944] message yesterday to see how he was doing. ㄴ ? To whom? ㄴ The Arch Lich. He said he was busy with his promotion match. Apparently, he was excited because winning this game would get him to Gold. ㄴ The guy above is fucking insane. ㄴ Zerobic is even more insane. Why the hell is that bastard suddenly taking a break? You're supposed to row while the tide is in. This is ridiculous. ㄴ Stop talking bullshit. The important thing is that if things continue like this, we can suppress this Monster Wave without suffering any more major losses. Let's pray that the situation ends soon and observe a moment of silence for the victims. ㄴ Hmm… I don't like China, but I agree with this. Idiots and normal people coexist in every country. Good luck to all the Hunters and soldiers. ㄴ Fighting.

The netizens were generally in high spirits.

The Monster Wave, which had initially been taken with deadly seriousness, had now become fodder for national pride. Even in the comments mourning the dead and cheering on those fighting, there was hope instead of fear.

Then again, we have been hearing a lot of good news lately.

[1942] Repeated 2s are Korean forum shorthand for agreeing with an earlier comment.

[1943] □□ represents trembling, often used online to express shock or amazement.

[1944] KakaoTalk is a messaging app widely used in South Korea.

The man nodded. It was only natural. According to the battlefield reports from the UN Security Council, there was no doubt that the tide had already turned decisively.

A week ago, the surprise attack launched simultaneously against all five fronts had caused enormous damage. But reinforcements far exceeding the number of casualties had been dispatched, and victory after victory had followed.

At this rate, it might be over in a few days.

Their momentum was unstoppable, like splitting bamboo. The Western Front under Jin Taekyung and the northern front led by Lee Jungryong stood out the most.

The little punk. I was so worried about him at first, but he's doing even better than I expected.

After a moment's hesitation, the man logged into the site and left a comment.

> └ **Jin Taekyung's Roommate:** Is this really the same loser Jin Taekyung? The real Jin Taekyung is a legend. I used to eat ramen with him all the time back in the day, and now he's become an S-rank Hunter, a king-like existence, and the world's strongest legendary hero. Looking at Jin Taekyung now honestly brings tears to my eyes…

Replies began springing up like weeds the instant he posted it.

The man gazed down at his phone with a pleased expression.

Then Seong Jinho suddenly realized he had forgotten something important.

"No! My ramen!"

"Man, I could really go for some ramen."

At my mutter, Team Leader Choi, who stood beside me, asked, "Out of nowhere?"

Having finished recovering, he had rejoined us at the front aboard a jet last night.

"Yeah. Weird, isn't it?"

"Considering the situation, you seem even more impressive, Mr. Jin."

Slash!

Hero's Soul flashed through the air, slicing through both the Lizardman's weapon and its body.

Green blood gushed out, accompanied by a stench that stabbed straight into my nose. My appetite vanished in an instant as I launched myself forward.

Fwoooosh! Boom!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Terrible heat engulfed dozens of Lizardmen and burst into flames. The monsters recoiling at the sight already looked like routed soldiers.

Reading the flow of battle, Xiao Shen charged to the front and shouted.

“Charge! Charge!”

“Waaaaaah!”

“Blade of the wind, descend upon this place! Wind Cutter!”

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish!

Clang! Slash!

—Kueeeek!

—Kiruk, krk!

Overwhelmed by the human offensive pouring down like a wave, the monsters were helplessly driven back.

Their numbers were roughly even, but the monsters were no match for us in either morale or the quality of their forces.

Once the front line collapsed like a sandcastle, several terrified monsters turned and fled.

And collapse happens in an instant.

Fear was contagious.

When one fled, ten followed. After that came an uncontrollable rout.

Sure enough, my prediction proved correct, and cries of certain victory soon rang out.

“Pursue them! Don’t let a single one survive!”

“Get the speed buffs up!”

“Ranged units! Ready—fire!”

Shwish-shwish! Boom!

The Hunters, their momentum at its peak, began slaughtering the monsters fleeing without even maintaining formation.

It did not take long for the six-lane asphalt road, which would have been packed with cars only a month ago, to become buried beneath monster corpses.

“We won again.”

After the battle, I was checking my equipment when Team Leader Choi approached me. I shrugged.

“For someone delivering good news, you don’t look very happy.”

“That’s strange. I was just thinking the same thing while looking at you, Mr. Jin.”

“…Hmm.”

Apparently, we had been thinking along the same lines.

Just as he said, I felt no joy at all despite our victory.

I had first noticed this same sense of unease on the second day after we launched our mobile campaign for the full-scale counterattack.

"What do you think, Team Leader Choi?"

"What exactly are you asking about? The sharp decline in both the number and quality of the monsters? Or the dozens of victories you've won over the past week?"

"Both."

"You're probably thinking exactly what I am. The current state of the war is certainly encouraging, but… something doesn't feel right."

Team Leader Choi looked toward the celebrating people.

Smiles spread across exhausted faces, each one filled with the hope that the war would soon end and they could return to the arms of their loved ones.

"It's not that I can't understand how this happened. There were so many high-level monsters during the early stages of the war. If they lost their elite forces, it would explain the current situation. But…"

"The Arch Lich. That bastard wouldn't make things this easy for us. Would he, Team Leader Choi?"

Team Leader Choi nodded slightly.

"Does command share our suspicions?"

"Probably. I don't know about the other S-rank Hunters, but Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu understood the situation perfectly."

"That's a relief, but…"

Team Leader Choi trailed off. Once again, he had probably arrived at the same thought I had.

We were practically at our destination, Suining City.

The Arch Lich had not shown himself even once throughout the entire war. What the hell was he doing right now?

"Hmm. He should be greasing his bones about now. Becoming a magnificent undead requires proper maintenance, you know."

"…"

Shut up already.

Whoooosh.

A vast space.

The darkness swirling within it was drawn toward a single point.

As the pitch-black darkness vanished, the light of the setting sun streamed through shattered windows and fell upon a solitary being.

"Come, Adversary."

The voice was as cold as the winter wind.
Having gathered his magical power, the Arch Lich’s eyes gleamed.

Chapter 407

Daniel Inoue was Japanese American.

A former Navy SEAL, he had awakened as an A-rank Hunter at the age of thirty. After leaving the military, he joined a private military company, where he put his abilities to excellent use.

Mercenary work suited Inoue well enough. He had to spend half of every year in conflict zones across the Middle East and Africa, but the pay was enormous, and he got long stretches of time off.

He had joined the response to the Monster Wave in China for much the same reason.

“Hey, ninja. What are you thinking about?”

At his comrade’s sudden question, Inoue narrowed his eyes.

“Shut up, Sam. Aren’t you sick of that damn ninja crap yet?”

“What’s the big deal? You should be used to it by now.”

“That’s exactly why I’m sick of it. Try being called a ninja or samurai since you were seven. It’ll drive you insane.”

“Why? Sounds pretty good to me.”

“You damn Yankee bastard.”

“I’ll take that as a compliment. I’m a Yankees fan.”

The small white man snickered at Inoue’s grumbling.

“Just accept it already. At this point, it’s fate. Even your abilities are totally ninja-like.”

“…Damn it.”

Inoue muttered a quiet curse.

Just as his comrade had said, the ability he had received upon awakening was perfectly suited to stealth.

Thanks to it, he had become a specialist in espionage and targeted assassinations. Unfortunately, it had also cemented his image as a ninja.

“I heard your girlfriend’s pregnant. How about naming the baby Naruto[1945]?”

Inoue raised his middle finger at his relentlessly annoying comrade.

“If you name your son Sasuke, I’ll think about it.”

“Oh, not bad.”

Quiet snickers escaped from the people around them.

The atmosphere, stiff and tense only moments ago, began to loosen. Inoue and his comrade exchanged faint smiles.

[1945] *Naruto* is a Japanese manga and anime series about ninjas. Sasuke is another name from the series.

The two had been close friends and partners for years. Their exchange had been little more than a skit meant to ease the tension before the mission began.

Too much tension only makes people commit one mistake after another.

That was true in battle, but even more so during an intelligence operation like this one.

They were entering unknown territory where neither communications nor magic could be used. Worse, their opponent was not some stupid, brutal rebel leader, but the Arch Lich that had unleashed an unprecedented Monster Wave.

No matter how favorable the war is going, we can't afford to let our guard down.

Having reminded himself of that, Inoue addressed the twenty intelligence operatives.

"Listen up. From this point on, we'll infiltrate in pairs. Use hand signals to communicate, and fire your signal flare in an emergency. You've all memorized your destinations and routes down to the last detail, right?"

"Yes."

"Good. Then… we meet back here in three hours. Dismissed."

At Inoue's words announcing the start of the operation, the intelligence operatives nodded and scattered in every direction. Watching them disappear silently and swiftly, his partner Sam jerked his chin toward the path ahead.

"Should we get moving too, ninja?"

"Yeah, you carefree Yankee bastard."

"Don't be like that. You're the best at this. Three hours from now, you'll be on your way back after finding out what color underwear the Arch Lich is wearing."

"…I really hope so."

Inoue let out a quiet sigh and stepped forward. The pale fog blanketing Suining City clung damply to his entire body.

The advance of the five fronts, which had seemed unstoppable, finally came to a halt.

We were two hundred kilometers[1946] from Suining City, where the Arch Lich was located. While we rested and reorganized, a welcome face came to visit.

"Hey, Korean friends. How have you been?"

I sensed a considerable wave of qi nearby, and sure enough, it was him. I bumped fists with Magic Johnson and answered.

"Pretty well."

"Jin. My lovable Miracle Boy. I missed you."

[1946] Two hundred kilometers is about 124 mi.

“Sorry, but could you leave out the ‘lovable’ part?”

“Then I’ll call you Crazy Boy. You did pull off something crazy, after all.”

Magic Johnson grinned and added,

“And incredibly heroic. The same goes for Choi here.”

Team Leader Choi, who had been carefully polishing Hero’s Soul, inclined his head.

“It’s good to see you again, Mr. Johnson.”

“Choi, don’t be like that. You’re making things stiff.”

“…!”

“…!”

“The atmosphere, of course.”

Magic Johnson threw back his head and laughed.

At this point, it was obvious he enjoyed watching our reactions. He was surprisingly playful for such a huge man.

Well, by now, we knew that everything was a joke whenever we met Magic Johnson.

Even Team Leader Choi, who always did Kegel exercises whenever he met him, gave a quiet laugh before asking,

“But what brings you here?”

“An emergency summons from headquarters. It’s an important matter.”

I frowned and muttered,

“This feels like déjà vu. Haven’t we seen this setup before?”

“Don’t worry, Jin. Nothing like last time will happen.”

By “last time,” he meant our main camp getting completely wrecked while the S-rank Hunters were away.

Well, the distance between the fronts had narrowed now. Even if everyone gathered together, we were practically close enough to touch noses if we fell over, so it should be fine.

If they aren’t handling this over communications, it must be that important.

As the Allied Forces continued winning and the monsters retreated, the Arch Lich’s territory had shrunk all the way back to Suining City. At our current location, both communications and magic worked smoothly.

“Do you know what we’re gathering for?”

“No. But I can guarantee it won’t be pleasant. I’ll stake my life on it.”

“…”

Please. Don’t stake your life on something like that. Give us a little more hope.

But Magic Johnson, as confident as ever, held out his hands to Team Leader Choi and me.

“Anyway, everyone else is already there. You two are the last guests.”

“Then please take us there, Mr. Johnson.”

Team Leader Choi took his hand without hesitation. Having already experienced Magic Johnson’s teleportation once, I nervously grabbed his fingers.

“Please drive safely—Gyaaaaaaaah!”

Whoooosh!

With the sensation of my entire body being crushed like a soda can, I was flung into a new space.

“Gyaaaaaaa…”

“…”

“…”

Damn it. Of all places, it had to be here.

A dozen pairs of eyes stared at me in silence. Under the dumbfounded gazes of the S-rank Hunters and senior Chinese generals, I stopped screaming and quietly slipped into an empty seat.

“Are we not starting the meeting?”

After a moment at a loss for words, Minister of National Defense Wei Fenghu finally spoke.

“…Then let us begin the meeting.”

The meeting that followed focused on a single subject: the information brought back by the intelligence team’s sole survivor.

“Daniel Inoue, who was in charge of the intelligence team, escaped from Suining City after eight hours—far beyond the scheduled operation time—and reported discovering a monster army numbering around thirty thousand.”

Thirty thousand…

It was an enormous force, but still well within the range we had expected.

The Arch Lich’s monster army had suffered its first defeat a week ago and had been retreating helplessly ever since, sustaining tremendous losses along the way.

“Judging by your expression, Minister, that isn’t all.”

Few people present could speak so casually to Minister Wei Fenghu.

Lee Jungryong was one of them. Whatever his personal feelings toward me, he had more than earned that right.

“Mr. Lee is correct. Thirty thousand is only the estimate based on what Inoue personally witnessed. The true number…”

“Could be twice that. Perhaps even more.”

“That is correct.”

“…Hmm.”

Low groans rose from around the room. We had expected the enemy to be holding forces in reserve for the final battle, but not that many.

Wei Fenghu continued solemnly.

“However, most of the monsters are likely to be mid- or low-level. That is our one small consolation.”

“The same is true of our forces, Wei Fenghu.”

At the remark from Faye Chen, who had been silently sipping from a liquor glass, Prince Felix nodded.

“She is right. More troops than expected have joined our side, but we still cannot be certain of victory.”

“Damn it. Those monsters never end, no matter how many we kill.”

I couldn’t help snorting at Wu Heixing’s grumbling.

“Why are you laughing?”

“Because it’s funny, you idiot.”

“What?”

“Anyone listening would think you’d been fighting your ass off. You’re the bastard who tried to take a detour during the monster army’s attack a week ago because you thought arriving early might be dangerous.”

“…!”

His expression was a sight to behold.

He must have thought no one knew, but word of Wu Heixing’s disgrace had already spread across every front.

“I know you’ve had a rough time too, but don’t whine in front of me or anyone else. Just looking at you is starting to piss me off.”

“Iik…!”[1947]

“What are you, self-employed? Why do you keep going *iik*?”

Wu Heixing’s face turned bright red. His body twitched as though he might charge at me at any moment, but that was as far as he could go.

The bitter memory of defeat lingered.

A hothouse flower that had spent its whole life being treated like royalty was bound to wither in a cold wind.

Of course, there were flowers of an entirely different sort.

Like Team Leader Choi, who was sitting beside me.

“That’s enough, both of you.”

At Team Leader Choi’s calm intervention, Wu Heixing glared at him.

“Are you ordering me around?”

“If that’s how you took it, I’m sorry to hear that, Wu Heixing.”

“You…”

[1947] *Iik* is an angry Korean grunt that sounds identical to the Korean word for “profit.”

Team Leader Choi did not so much as blink at Wu Heixing's threatening aura. Wu Heixing shot to his feet.

No, he tried to.

"Sit."

"…!"

My aura struck like an awl, and his body locked in place.

The other S-rank Hunters turned startled eyes toward me.

I glanced at Lee Jungryong's deeply sunken gaze before continuing.

"Just so there's no misunderstanding, yes, that was an order."

"You, you…!"

"Sit. I won't say it again."

Whoooosh!

A wave of aura surged toward him, and Wu Heixing's lower lip trembled.

Perhaps he would have counted as a genius even in Murim.

No, he definitely would have. Becoming an S-rank Hunter in his thirties would have been impossible without that level of talent.

But he was only half the package.

Awakening was an unearned windfall. Like a lottery winner, he had received extraordinary abilities and mana the moment he turned twenty.

And he was supposed to build up internal energy like a Murim practitioner and master martial arts at the Supreme Peak level?

Well…

Learning martial arts might make up for his technical shortcomings, but there was no doubt he would fall by the wayside long before he ever reached that point.

Compared to his talent, his effort and will were Third Rate.

"Enough."

Lee Jungryong's gentle baritone broke the tension.

The old snake, still looking like a handsome middle-aged man despite being well past sixty, watched me with a smile.

"I thought only your skills had improved, but your killing intent has grown stronger too."

I met his eyes impassively.

"Rolling around in all sorts of places tends to put an edge on you."

"I heard the Western Front was particularly fierce."

"That's not wrong. Want to come see the Western Front?"

"I must politely decline. If it was fierce enough that only three people survived, I think I'll pass."

"…!"

“The older I get, the more cowardly I become. Ho ho.”

The blood in my veins turned cold.

That horrific battlefield flashed before my eyes, and before I knew it, a faint smile had formed on my lips.

“What are you trying to say?”

“Let’s think about something more productive than turning on our allies. Planning for the final battle would be a good place to start. Jin Taekyung, what do you think?”

I quietly tapped the armrest of my chair.

My insides twisted, but Lee Jungryong’s words had struck at the heart of the matter.

He was right. The battle bearing down on us was practically at our doorstep. That was what we needed to deal with now.

Then one thought came to me.

“A suicide squad.”

“A suicide squad?”

Everyone’s eyes turned toward me. Some nodded in agreement, while others looked uneasy.

But both reason and instinct told me this was our best chance to win while minimizing our losses.

“We gather our very best and cut off the head.”

Once the Arch Lich is destroyed, the undead army will collapse.

Chapter 408

“A suicide squad.”

The moment those words left Jin Taekyung’s mouth, Wu Heixing forgot his rising anger and nearly shouted.

You crazy bangzi[1948] bastard!

A suicide squad.

Wasn’t that exactly what it meant—to charge in prepared to die?

Even if they somehow broke through the monster army without knowing its exact numbers, the real monster—the Arch Lich—would be waiting behind it. The mere thought made Wu Heixing’s hair stand on end.

This… this is insane.

Wu Heixing didn’t care how many casualties they suffered.

China was a Great Nation with a population of over a billion, after all. Even if a hundred thousand or a million people vanished, they would amount to no more than a handful.

In fact, if that damn bangzi[1949] took the vanguard of the suicide squad and died a glorious death, Wu Heixing would happily raise both hands in celebration.

But…

“Let’s gather our very best and take out the head.”

That meant Wu Heixing himself would be included in the suicide squad. And he had no intention of taking even the slightest risk.

“Cut that ridiculous bullshit—”

Unable to hold back any longer, Wu Heixing shot to his feet and opened his mouth.

“Oh, that’s an excellent idea.”

“…!”

Wu Heixing stared wide-eyed, unable to continue.

He had never imagined that Lee Jungryong would side with Jin Taekyung.

Not just anyone, but Lee Jungryong himself.

“W-What did you just say?”

“I said it was an excellent idea.”

Lee Jungryong continued with a gentle smile.

“We need to end this battle as quickly as possible. The Arch Lich is likely creating new undead even now. If the S-rank Hunters lead the advance and destroy it, the monster army—made up mostly of undead—will collapse, reducing our casualties.”

[1948] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

[1949] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

"M-Mr. Lee."

"I imagine you agree with me. Just like everyone else here. Isn't that right, Mr. Wu?"

"Everyone else? What are you talking about?"

Only then did Wu Heixing look around in confusion.

Not only Wei Fenghu and the other high-ranking Chinese generals, but also Faye Chen, Magic Johnson, and even Prince Felix were nodding slightly as they exchanged opinions.

"Hmm. Certainly…"

"Even if we reinforce our forces, the Arch Lich will do the same. The longer we drag this out, the larger the battle will become."

"What if we select A-rank Hunters and other veterans, deploy them to one side, and have the S-rank Hunters lead the breakthrough?"

"It would be dangerous, but the plan has a real chance of success."

"No matter how powerful a Named Monster the Arch Lich may be, we should have a good chance if the S-rank Hunters attack it together."

Wu Heixing's face went white as the conversation reached his ears.

Have these people lost their minds?

They were actually looking favorably upon this insane operation. They must have all gone mad.

Even Lee Jungryong, whom Wu Heixing had trusted, had sided with Jin Taekyung for some reason.

Desperate to avoid being included in the suicide squad, Wu Heixing hurriedly turned toward Jin Taekyung.

"W-Wait! If all the S-rank Hunters leave, wouldn't that create a massive hole in our forces?"

"Gasp."

Jin Taekyung sucked in a startled breath and looked at Wu Heixing in surprise.

"Wow. You do use your brain once in a while."

"…"

"You're right. We should probably leave a few people behind."

That damn bangzi[1950].

But this was no time to get angry. Wu Heixing suppressed his surging fury and continued.

"R-Right. So, to prepare for any unforeseen circumstances, I—"

Jin Taekyung abruptly cut him off and turned toward Magic Johnson.

"It seems like you should stay behind. What do you think, Johnson?"

[1950] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

"Me?"

What kind of situation was this? Wu Heixing desperately tried to intervene.

"M-Magic Johnson? Wouldn't it be better to have at least one mage come with us?"

"Of course that would be good. It would—but…"

Jin Taekyung gave Wu Heixing a pleasant smile.

"What about the rear?"

"Huh?"

"What happens if the Arch Lich teleports behind our lines and attacks us from the rear? Are you going to stop it?"

"…"

"No matter how powerful the Arch Lich is, it won't be able to pull something like that if a grand mage stays behind to interfere with its magic. And Magic Johnson's wide-area magic could turn the tide of the battle."

Every word made perfect sense. Wu Heixing's mouth snapped shut, and Jin Taekyung clicked his tongue.

"Think before you run your mouth. Stop watching those 'watch your rear' GIFs on the internet and start thinking about the rear in an actual war."

"…!"

Ignoring Wu Heixing, who had frozen like a statue, Jin Taekyung asked Magic Johnson,

"What do you think?"

"You're right, Jin. So I'm the only one staying behind?"

Defense Minister Wei Fenghu, who had been silently observing the situation, suddenly spoke.

"The Arch Lich must have held a large number of high-level monsters in reserve for the final battle. Far more than the number of A-rank Hunters on our side. We will need at least two more S-rank Hunters to maintain an evenly matched battlefield."

It wasn't over yet. Two spots still remained.

Finding a glimmer of hope, Wu Heixing cleared his throat.

"Then I suppose I have no choice but to stay—"

"If the others have no objections, I would first like to exclude Prince Felix."

"What?"

"I'm sorry, but I cannot explain the details. There is a complicated issue involved."

Felix was not merely an S-rank Hunter. He was a member of the royal family and practically a symbol of the United Kingdom. Nor was he some insignificant member of a distant branch. He was third in line to the throne.

Everyone present understood that the "complicated issue" Wei Fenghu could not explain was a diplomatic problem with the United Kingdom.

“Well, his father is the King of the United Kingdom, so I suppose that’s possible. Then the prince is out.”

At Jin Taekyung’s words, Prince Felix spoke with an uncomfortable expression.

“I hope you understand that this is not my choice. However, I have been bound to the royal family since birth, and I cannot disobey my royal father’s command—”

“It’s fine. I don’t care. I’d actually prefer it this way, since it would leave a bad taste in my mouth if the United Kingdom’s fourth in line to the throne got hurt during the operation I proposed.”

“Third! And show proper respect when speaking to me.”

“Oh, right. Congratulations on the bronze medal. Then, does anyone object to His Highness Prince Felix, that living hotbed of entrenched privilege, sitting this one out thanks to his connections?”

Wu Heixing started to raise his hand without thinking, only to stop when Faye Chen and Lee Jungryong answered.

“I don’t mind.”

“I agree.”

Jin Taekyung nodded and fixed Wu Heixing with a long stare.

“What about you?”

“M-Me?”

“When the only guy left asks that, what am I supposed to tell him? Tinky Winky, Dipsy, or Po. Pick one.”

There was no way out.

Magic Johnson and Prince Felix were foreigners, and both had legitimate reasons to remain behind. Even Faye Chen and Lee Jungryong had agreed.

Wu Heixing squeezed his eyes shut, opened them again, and muttered,

“…Agreed.”

“Answer properly. If you say it like that, how the hell am I supposed to know whether you mean agreement or *Donguibogam*?[1951] Are you Heo Jun?”

“I… agree.”

“Okay.”

It happened at Quick Attack[1952] speed.

One spot still remained, but Wu Heixing felt a sense of foreboding.

And it didn’t take long for that foreboding to become certainty.

“I would like Faye Chen to fill the final position.”

But what had thrown Wu Heixing into confusion was that it wasn’t Jin Taekyung who had blocked his last escape route.

[1951] *Donguibogam* is a seventeenth-century Korean medical encyclopedia. The joke plays on *dongui*, meaning “agreement,” at the start of its title.

[1952] Quick Attack is a rapid-movement move in *Pokémon*.

It was Lee Jungryong.

What in the world is that old man thinking?

Wu Heixing vividly remembered the conversation he had shared with Lee Jungryong on the day Jin Taekyung had trampled him into the ground.

He clearly suggested that we join forces. And now he's stabbing me in the back like this?

Faye Chen glanced at Wu Heixing as he ground his teeth, then tipped back her liquor glass.

"Well, Mr. Lee, I'm not the sort who enjoys danger. But wouldn't our odds of success be higher if we left that brat behind instead of me?"

"No, Faye Chen. You will do more to reduce casualties by remaining behind."

"You don't know that kid. Just looking at him makes even someone who never had any patriotism develop some."

"Don't worry. I'll be here."

His tone was calm but filled with certainty.

Only Lee Jungryong could say such a thing with such confidence.

The old hero's gaze, carrying an assurance no one present could deny, settled on one person.

"And Jin Taekyung. You'll be there too, won't you?"

His eyes were deep and unreadable.

Jin Taekyung silently met Lee Jungryong's gaze before answering.

"Our dear Vice Guild Master certainly has a talent for making the obvious sound complicated."

"May I take that to mean you will also be joining the suicide squad?"

"Of course."

"Brave. Heroic, even. In that case, I'll yield the vanguard to you."

"Great. Does that mean I get to leave behind a famous quote like Louis Armstrong? Something like, 'This is one small step for a man, but for monsters, it's the Heavenly Demon's Reign.'"

"That's rather crude for a quote destined for the history books. And you have the name wrong. It wasn't Louis Armstrong. It was Neil Armstrong."

"You're certainly well educated. Still, your academic credentials have nothing on the length of my tissue roll.[1953]"

The people around them developed pounding headaches trying to follow Jin Taekyung's answers, while Wu Heixing fell into despair.

Until barely a month ago, he had been enjoying a lavish yacht party surrounded by dozens of beautiful women.

[1953] The Korean joke contrasts a "long schoolbag strap," meaning extensive education, with a "long tissue roll," implying extensive experience with pornography.

Now he had been assigned to a suicide squad prepared to die.

And then, in the very next moment—

—Do you think I betrayed you?

“…!”

—Accept it. I promise there will be no danger.

As the Sound Transmission pierced his ears, Wu Heixing slowly raised his head.

Lee Jungryong was looking at him with a gentle smile as he continued speaking.

“He’ll carry out his assigned duty well. I guarantee it.”

Jin Taekyung slowly tapped the armrest of his chair as he replied,

“I’m looking forward to seeing just how brilliantly he carries out his duty.”

The rather lengthy meeting came to an end.

The suicide squad would be led by S-rank Hunters, with high-level A-rank Hunters and veteran B-rank Hunters making up the rest. The command staff would be working around the clock to select its members.

The Skeleton Warlord had remained silent throughout the meeting. But the moment we returned to the tent assigned to me on the Western Front, it solemnly declared,

“This commander will sit out this battle.”

“Yeah, fuck off.”

“At least ask why, you treacherous human.”

“Fine. Why?”

“As the commander of an undead army, this commander is reluctant to fight his own kind.”

I answered with a dumbfounded expression.

“What the fuck are you talking about? Who’s been sucking the energy out of his own kind to nourish himself this whole time?”

“…Oh.”

“Let’s be honest. If you said you just didn’t want to go because you were scared of the Arch Lich, would I curse at you?”

“You would.”

“You son of a—… Oh.”

The Skeleton Warlord’s distrust of me deepened even further as it spoke.

“In any case, this commander no longer wishes to take part in this war. Honor the promise you made that day.”

“The promise I made that day?”

“Have you ever seen such a treacherous human? Didn’t you promise that, in exchange for protecting two humans, you would grant any request I made?”

“Oh.”

It had been a while since I’d been left speechless.

I had definitely made that promise. Normally, I would have brushed it off by pretending to have amnesia, but this time I couldn’t ignore it in good conscience.

“Fine. What’s your wish?”

The Skeleton Warlord shouted as though it had been waiting for the question.

“Give me freedom!”

“Freedom?”

“That is correct. You, treacherous human, have insulted and abused this commander all this time! No fewer than 408 times!”

“…Did you come from an animal rights group or something?”

“Honor your promise! This commander shall finally find freedom!”

Freedom.

My head was already cluttered with thoughts of Lee Jungryong, so a wish like that hadn’t even occurred to me.

After thinking for a moment, I answered.

“Fine. I’ll give you freedom.”

“Ooh! Oooooh!”

“Goodbye, then.”

“Huh?”

Without hesitation, I pulled the Skeleton Warlord’s skull from my Inventory and threw it outside the tent.

Into the middle of the thousands of Hunters swarming around outside.

Clack!

The sound of it hitting something rang out, and the area around the tent erupted into chaos. Shouts came from every direction, followed by the thunderous roar of exploding magic.

“Monster! Monster attack!”

“Kill it!”

Boom! Kaboom!

How much time passed?

Five minutes? Ten?

Rustle, rustle.

The bottom edge of the tent suddenly began to shift. Then a black, glossy skull rolled in and stopped at my feet.

“Oh, look who it is.”

“…”
“What brings the Skeleton Warlord, proud owner of a free spirit, here?”
“You… human…”
A red glow flickered pitifully within the skull’s empty eye sockets.
Was I imagining it, or was an undead actually whimpering?
The Skeleton Warlord continued in a tearful voice.
“Can I… take back my wish?”
“Oh, of course.”
I continued in the chipper tone of a customer-service representative.
“But you know wish coupons can’t be exchanged or refunded, right?”
“…”
“Come here, Golgoli.”
Hop.
The Skeleton Warlord feebly jumped into my arms.

Chapter 409

An unannounced visitor arrived before dawn had fully broken.

He stepped carefully into the tent and met my eyes as I sat cross-legged.

“You were already awake.”

“As you can see.”

I shrugged at Team Leader Choi.

“I haven’t been sleeping much lately.”

More accurately, I needed less sleep.

With stamina that had surpassed human limits and formidable internal energy amounting to three jiazi,[1954] I could blow away most fatigue by circulating my qi.

“Were you practicing the Mana Cultivation Method—or rather, the Jin Family’s Cultivation Technique?”

“Yeah, something like that.”

To be exact, I was practicing the Fire Gate Divine Technique, the secret cultivation technique of the Fire Gate Clan. But I couldn’t tell him every last detail.

“I should have come later.”

“No, it’s fine.”

“Didn’t you say that cultivation must never be interrupted? That stopping midway could cause qi deviation…”

“Oh, that applies to you, Team Leader Choi. I’m fine. We’re on different levels.”

“…”

Warning: your fact attack may hurt someone.

For a moment, I could practically see the public-service announcement flashing across Team Leader Choi’s face.

He gave me a sour look, then slowly shook his head.

“I can’t argue with the truth.”

“Still, you’re learning incredibly fast. I mean that sincerely, so have a little more confidence.”

I did mean it. As befitted a descendant of Cheon Taemin, the hero who had achieved an indomitable feat in human history, Team Leader Choi possessed extraordinary natural martial talent.

For some reason, he also had a considerable amount of qi stored within his body, so his progress in martial arts was astonishingly fast.

In short, he was a talent with all the groundwork already laid.

If he’d learned martial arts from childhood like Wu Heixing… he’d probably be an S-rank Hunter by now.

[1954] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi is 180 years.

Team Leader Choi's expression softened slightly, and he nodded.

"How do I compare to Jin Taekyung?"

"Are you kidding? Of course I learned faster."

"…"

Who are you trying to compare yourself to?

Team Leader Choi might have grown up under Lee Jungryong's watchful eye, constantly held in check, but our lives had been fundamentally different.

Even after obtaining the System, I'd nearly died several times. Damn it, I'd been through hell.

"Anyway, what brings you here this early?"

"Something has been troubling me, so I came despite the imposition."

"Something troubling you?"

"Yes."

"Why? Did Johnson confess his love to you?"

"That doesn't concern me. I know it's simply Mr. Johnson's way of showing affection. This is about Guild business."

"Guild business… Did bad news come from Korea?"

At my worried question, Team Leader Choi shook his head.

"No. I'm worried because one of our Guild members seems to be heading into danger."

"Oh."

So that was what he meant. Once I caught on, I let out a quiet laugh.

"I know who you mean. Tall and handsome, right? With an absolutely wonderful personality."

"I can't speak to the first two, but his personality certainly is something else. In several ways."

"Hmm. Then I don't think we're talking about the same person."

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

Team Leader Choi, who had been trading jokes with me until then, lowered his voice.

"You know what I mean."

"Do I?"

"This operation is dangerous."

"Team Leader Choi, don't you trust me?"

"How could I not? You're one of the people I trust most in this world."

Team Leader Choi fixed me with a grave stare.

"And you're about to carry out a dangerous operation with some of the people I trust least."

Two names immediately came to mind.

Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing. Men bound to me by bitter history—and comrades who would soon have to entrust their backs to one another.

I scratched my chin and answered.

"'People I can't trust.' I can't think of a more fitting description."

"Mr. Jin Taekyung…"

"Team Leader Choi?"

He closed his mouth before he could continue. I quietly raised a hand and pointed toward the tent flap.

"As you know, I haven't finished cultivating yet."

"…!"

"The battle will begin before the day is over. Clear your mind and prepare for the fight ahead."

Team Leader Choi stared at me, conflicted and unable to speak. At last, he heaved a deep sigh and rose from his seat.

"I'll see you shortly."

"Sure. I won't see you out."

I felt his presence gradually fade as he left the tent.

The Skeleton Warlord, who had been moping ever since his wish coupon was refunded, immediately spoke in a hopeful voice.

—A very intelligent human. It is not too late. Why not heed that human's advice?

"You're really working hard at this."

—If you insist on going, go alone! Why must you take this commander with you?

"Dying alone would be lonely."

—Whaaaaaat?!

"I'm joking. It's just our best option."

—You call breaking through a massive monster army to confront the Arch Lich our best option? Are you an evil human, or simply insane?

Listen to the way this undead bastard talks.

I considered punishing him, then unfolded my legs and reclined diagonally across the bed.

"It's a dangerous operation, sure, but we've got a good chance. Stop complaining."

—And what if we get there and it does not work?

"Then we fight with everything we've got. That'll give us a chance."

The Skeleton Warlord muttered with the voice of one who had attained enlightenment.

—Miraculous logic indeed. To think this commander is stuck with such a madman.

"And yet you're still here."

—Still here? You mean I cannot leave!

“You’re hilarious. When was it that you came back on your own feet? Ah, never mind. Not feet—your skull.”

—Vicious humans seeking this commander’s life are everywhere! What else was I supposed to do?

I let out a quiet laugh at the Skeleton Warlord’s aggrieved protest.

Don’t be such a coward.

I had plenty to say, but decided to save it for later. That was something he needed to realize on his own.

—You laughed! You just laughed!

“When?”

I played dumb and changed the subject.

“Anyway, the key is taking down the Arch Lich. Once the head is gone, the body can’t move.”

—Dullahans can.

“…”

That was true.

For a moment, the answer made perfect sense. Then I realized how ridiculous it was and pulled the Skeleton Warlord from my Inventory.

“No, seriously. This bastard has been asking for it.”

—C-Calm down, human. I said nothing untrue.

“Right. Dullahans can move without their heads. Let’s see what happens to the Skeleton Warlord.”

Crack!

I flicked his forehead with lightning speed, and the Skeleton Warlord shrieked.

—Agh! A crack! There’s a crack between my brows! I’m telling you, there’s really a crack!

“I held back, so what the hell are you talking about… Oh. There really is one.”

Maybe I should have hit him more gently. A tiny crack had appeared in the glossy black skull, its surface gleaming smoothly.

When I lightly touched the sliver of bone raised by the impact, the Skeleton Warlord screamed.

—My bone! My bone!

“Fine, I get it. Stop screaming.”

—My bones have been getting increasingly itchy and sensitive lately, and I was already worried, but this madman went and… Sob.

“…”

What, does he have dry skin?

At this rate, he would start an iTube channel and rack up a million subscribers as an undead beauty streamer.

This bastard might not even be a monster...

The more I saw of him, the stranger he seemed.

I stared at the Skeleton Warlord in disbelief, then suddenly threw open one side of the tent. The sun was slowly lifting its head in the east.

It signaled the beginning of a new day—and the battle soon to come.

Located in the central Sichuan Basin, Suining City encompassed two urban districts, three counties, and more than five thousand square kilometers[1955] of land.

Since ancient times, it had been known as the heart of central Sichuan Province, renowned for its refined culture, tranquil scenery, and thriving agriculture, industry, and commerce.

But all of that was now a thing of the past.

Caw! Cawww!

Countless crows wheeled through the overcast sky before descending upon the corpses strewn across the ground. There were no squabbles between the flocks over their prey.

Hundreds of bodies lay scattered across the land, and the crows filled their bellies by pecking at the rotting flesh of what had once been human beings.

For humanity, it was a calamity beyond compare.

For the crows, it was an age of peace and plenty.

Their peaceful feast did not last long.

Rumble. Rrrrumble.

A deafening roar and tremors rose from the ground. The crows cried out irritably and took flight as one.

Several black feathers drifted through the air, caught the wind, and sailed across the vast basin.

Countless marching feet and the metal wheels of tanks crushed the feathers as they fluttered down.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

A human army filled the horizon.

The tower shields held by the tank-class Hunters at the forefront scraped against the ground. Behind them, thousands of Hunters advanced in ordered ranks.

A pair of tightly pressed lips showed beneath a helmet pulled low.

[1955] Five thousand square kilometers is about 1,900 square miles.

Thousands of people, gripped by the invisible specter of war, marched onward in silence.

Toward the distant city shrouded in pale mist.

Toward the battle that awaited them, and the glorious victory beyond it.

Then a man at the center of the formation suddenly spoke.

“Fuck, look at that fog. Doesn’t it look like something out of one of those disaster movies where monsters show up? Anyone seen that one?”

Jin Taekyung’s colorful profanity came out of nowhere amid the solemn atmosphere, drawing snorts of laughter from all around him.

“Pfft.”

“Kff.”

“What? Am I the only one who’s seen it? That masterpiece?”

As Jin Taekyung shrugged, a voice answered from his right.

“I’ve seen it.”

“Really? That’s unexpected, Team Leader Choi.”

“What is?”

“You seem like the type who’d only watch musicals or orchestral performances. Things like that.”

The Hunters who glanced at Choi Minwoo bit their lips to hold back their laughter.

Before they knew it, their rigid bodies had relaxed and their breathing had steadied. The tension weighing on them eased considerably.

All the while, the two men continued their conversation.

“I occasionally watch movies to unwind. I enjoyed the one you mentioned too, Mr. Jin.”

“Oh, then you know the final twist.”

“Of course. Personally, I found it quite unfortunate.”

“Exactly. I had the same thought while I was watching.”

Jin Taekyung continued slowly.

“They could’ve survived if they hadn’t given up at the very end. They should’ve kept fighting with everything they had, no matter what it took. That sort of thing.”

His voice was low, but it carried unmistakable strength.

Infused with profound internal energy, it reverberated through the air and reached every ear.

And the thousands of Hunters and soldiers of the Western Front realized something.

Perhaps Jin Taekyung’s words had been meant for them.

“By now, the other fronts are probably surrounding Suining City just like we are, right?”

“They’ll have it completely encircled.”

“And the battle will begin soon.”

“We will win.”

Jin Taekyung laughed aloud at Xiao Shen’s resolute answer.

“Yeah. We have to. But…”

Jin Taekyung’s laughter abruptly stopped. The next moment, the playful light in his eyes vanished, replaced by a deeply sunken gaze.

The vast basin was reflected in his icy gaze.

“Looks like they have other ideas.”

Tap. Tap-tap-tap.

Grrrk…

Corpses slowly rose to their feet.

Skeletons.

Mist slid across the basin, carrying with it the growls of the monsters lurking within.

“Starting now…”

Jin Taekyung drew a deep breath.

“It begins.”

Chapter 410

Has it been over thirty years?

Lee Jungryong muttered to himself.

The stench of countless monsters and the reek of blood drifted in on the wind. It was the smell of a battlefield, stirring memories of long ago.

Yes. It truly has been a long time.

With a shrewd gaze that seemed at odds with his appearance, he watched the fog slowly draw nearer. The pale fog, where thousands of monsters were presumably lurking, radiated an ominous feeling simply by being there.

Most of the troops were shaken, but to Lee Jungryong—a living witness to the Great Cataclysm—it was an all-too-familiar sight.

“How old are you?”

At Lee Jungryong’s sudden question, Go Jun, the Head of Security standing one step behind him, answered.

“Thirty-five.”

“That’s a good age. Looking back, I was the same. Every day brought another brush with death, but I had dreams back then.”

Lee Jungryong gazed into the distance.

For a moment, he seemed to glimpse his younger self somewhere far away—a young man driven by the will to survive and the ambition to become the best.

But more than thirty years later, the man standing here was nearing seventy.

“Sometimes, doubt creeps in. I find myself wondering whether everything I’ve built might come crashing down.”

“I have not the slightest doubt.”

“Why not?”

Go Jun’s lips moved.

“Because you are here, Master.”

Lee Jungryong gave a quiet laugh.

“And what would you do if I fell?”

“I can say with certainty that will never happen.”

“There was a time when I thought the same of someone else. He was stronger than anyone, an insurmountable wall I could never overcome even if I devoted my entire life to trying.”

“…!”

“He was the beginning and end of the Great Cataclysm. He was everything. Humanity’s savior, no different from a new god. But even he was only human.”

The hero who had achieved immortal feats had not shown himself for many years, and only a handful of people knew the secret surrounding him.

As one of those few, Lee Jungryong continued in a low voice.

“Nothing is eternal, and nothing is certain. I’ve found myself thinking that more and more lately.”

“…Is this because of Jin Taekyung?”

“When a crack begins, collapse comes in an instant. That bastard is the crack itself.”

“Then we must seal it before everything collapses.”

Lee Jungryong watched the fog slide across the desolate plain. When he spoke, his voice was gentle, but a blade lay hidden beneath it.

“Are you ready?”

“I will obey.”

Go Jun bowed deeply and drew his sword.

Shing! Clatter!

Hundreds, then thousands, of weapons were drawn behind him at once.

The Ares Guild’s elites, honed through countless raids and training exercises, stood alongside the Chinese Hunters. The light gleaming from their weapons rippled like waves.

“Please give the command.”

Lee Jungryong slowly began to walk.

There was no place here for soldiers or firearms. This was a battle solely between the superhumans known as Hunters and the monsters—and Lee Jungryong would reign as the god of the battlefield.

“Let’s go.”

With that single word, Lee Jungryong shot forward like the wind. The fog filling the plain split apart on both sides along the path of his sword.

Kraaash!

Splurt!

Drenched in horribly foul-smelling green blood, the young man barely managed to keep from gagging.

No, that was not quite right.

It would be more accurate to say he was not even given the chance.

Whoosh! Boom!

The upper section of his Tower Shield shattered, and a sharp fragment grazed the tip of his nose. Blood spurted out, and the scent of it pierced his nostrils.

It helped drown out the terrible stench, but directly before him, an undead ogre that looked freshly dead was raising a massive iron club.

“Grrrraaaaah!”

Whooooooosh.

The terrifying sound of it tearing through the air was enough to make his hair stand on end.

The young man gritted his teeth and bent his knees, shielding his head with his mana-infused Tower Shield.

Boom!

The tremendous impact tore through his entire body. His ears rang, his head reeled, and his arm hurt as though it had been broken.

No. Maybe it’s already broken.

But a broken arm barely even counted as a problem right now.

Not when a ferociously roaring, five-meter-tall monster[1956] was swinging an iron club as large as a grown man like a pinwheel.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Under the relentless assault, the young man screamed, his voice edging toward tears.

“You turtle-dicked bastard! Why are you so strong?!”

The young man was a veteran B-rank Hunter. Naturally, he had fought ogres before.

As befitted A-rank monsters, ogres possessed tremendous strength and stamina, but they had never been this strong.

They definitely hadn’t been…

Boom!

The young man stared blankly as the high-strength Tower Shield he had bought for a fortune at the beginning of the year shattered after only five blows.

What the hell… Did all these things take drugs or something?

They were far too strong.

As he watched the iron club rise once more through the pale fog, the young man sensed that his end had come.

At the same time, one name flashed through his mind.

Jin Taekyung.

This was all that bastard’s fault.

If Jin Taekyung had simply pretended not to know him and walked past that day, some big shot would never have kicked him in the shins, and he would not have been drafted as a frontline tank.

[1956] Five meters is about 16.4 ft.

Then he would not be about to die like this.

Whooooooosh!

Dodging was unthinkable. He did not even have the courage to look straight at the iron club hurtling toward him, filling his entire field of vision.

The young man squeezed his eyes shut and let out an involuntary scream.

"Jin Taekyung, you bangzi bastard!"[1957]

And then, in the next instant—

Slash! Rattle-rattle-rattle!

His vision went pitch-black. A cool breeze brushed across his entire body, and something poured down like a sudden shower.

Soon, a voice pierced his ears.

"What did you just call me?"

"…Huh?"

The young man's eyes flew open. Green blood was scattering through the air in droplets. The enormous body of the undead ogre, now missing its head, was slowly toppling over.

And there was the face of a man scowling deeply.

"…Huh?"

"You're that bastard from last time. Burdian."

Whoosh! Splurt!

He had not seen it. There had been no way he could.

The man reached out, and a streak of light—probably a dagger—pierced three or four monsters. They crumpled like puppets with their strings cut.

An answer escaped the young man's lips before he could think.

"Uh, no, I'm not."

"No, my ass, you fucking bastard."

Slash! Bang!

"You looked like you were in danger, so I saved you, and you call me a bangzi?[1958] You'd better survive. I'm going to make you run bread for me until you die of old age."

Slash! Sssshk!

Is this a dream?

Every time the young man blinked, the monsters around him fell like bundles of straw.

[1957] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean. Jin's reply plays on the sound of *ppang*, the Korean word for bread, and *ppang shuttle*, slang for someone made to run errands.

[1958] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean. Jin's reply plays on the sound of *ppang*, the Korean word for bread, and *ppang shuttle*, slang for someone made to run errands.

Blue flames erupted, and whenever the air split with a shriek, an area that had been so densely packed there was nowhere to step was swept clean.

It all began at one man's fingertips, and none of it looked like something a human being could have done.

The young man stared at him in a daze.

"Are you… perhaps a god?"

After a moment of silence, Jin Taekyung asked in return,

"Are you perhaps… a fucking idiot?"

Rrrrummmble!

Blue flames swept across the earth. Steel melted, and monsters engulfed in the blaze screamed in agony.

After wiping out dozens of monsters with a single sweep, Jin Taekyung glanced at the young man.

"Hey."

"Yes? Yes?"

"Survive. I'm going to make you run bread for me."

"Excuse me?"

"I'm not joking. If you die, I'll kill you myself."

"…!"

"Oh, and take this."

Whoosh! Crack!

Something shot toward the young man like a ray of light, struck him in the forehead, and shattered.

Before he could react, translucent liquid drenched him, and Jin Taekyung's low voice reached his ears.

"You'll be fine now, so get back to fighting. Don't go picking fights with ogres unless you want to get yourself killed. Stick to the weaker ones. Got it?"

Hissss.

The liquid—no, the potion—seeped into him with a faint warmth.

The young man felt the wounds covering his body close and his broken arm mend. He nodded blankly.

"Yes. Yes."

"Then I'm off."

"P-Please be careful, sir."

Forgetting that he was in the middle of a battlefield, the young man bowed deeply at the waist.

When he raised his head again, Jin Taekyung was gone, and a group was rushing past him.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! Slash!

More than two hundred Hunters raced forward without hesitation along the path Jin Taekyung had opened, swinging their weapons.

Two figures at the forefront stood out above all the rest.

“&*^%!”

“Their formation has collapsed! Charge!”

One was a handsome man spouting incomprehensible Korean. The other was a remarkably young-looking Hunter.

They moved like the wind, their blades wreathed in dazzling aura as they cut the monsters apart.

The suicide squad.

He had heard about them. A number of S-rank Hunters, including Jin Taekyung, would lead the suicide squads from each front in a charge against the Arch Lich.

Only yesterday, he had thought it was impossible nonsense…

Amazing.

Could I become like that too?

As the young man gazed blankly at the scene, his chest suddenly grew hot. Some unknown strength surged up from within him, and he could not contain it.

He raised his half-destroyed Tower Shield and charged toward the nearest monster.

“Yaaaaaaaah!”

“Grrrraaaaah!”

Whoosh! Boom!

“…”

Damn it. It was an ogre.

The young man stared at his now completely shattered Tower Shield, turned on his heel, and ran.

Orcs. Where are the orcs?!

Thud!

That did it.

The impact against my knuckles told me all I needed to know. As certainty flashed through my mind, the head of the Lycanthrope lunging teeth-first for the back of my neck exploded.

SYSTEM

***Ding!* - You defeated Lv. 92 Darkened Lycanthrope! - You gained a small amount of EXP!**

A Lycanthrope at level ninety-something?

I already knew Level was not an absolute measure, but the monsters gathered on this battlefield were clearly different from the ones I had encountered in Gates.

They're stronger.

Their Levels were slightly higher, and they were superior in Agility and raw strength as well.

If it had been one or two monsters, I might have brushed it off. But everything from F-rank goblins to A-rank monsters was like this. You would have to be an idiot not to realize something was wrong.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung!"

"Hyung!"[1959]

I turned at the urgent shouts behind me and saw monsters packing the path I had opened, leaving no gaps between them.

The suicide squad was fighting desperately against them.

"Get the hell out of here. All of you."

Boom-boom-boom-boom!

To the monsters, I was something they could neither stop nor evade.

Dozens of fist shadows shot out like cannonballs and rained down upon their heads.

Some were reduced to bloody pulp and hurled into the distance. Others simply crumpled where they stood.

I charged into the space that had momentarily been emptied.

Slash-slash-slash!

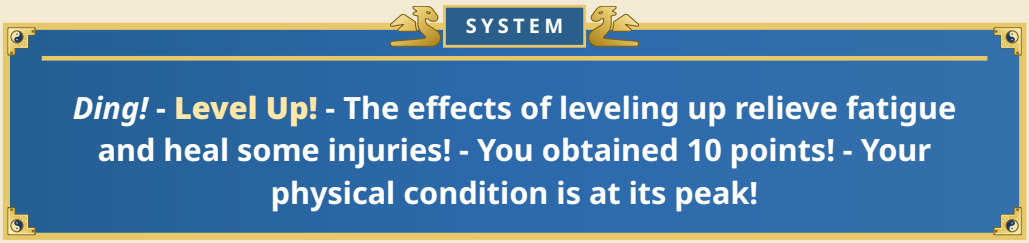
A spearhead wreathed in Force tore through bone and flesh, carving through everything around me. As the monsters fell, System notifications rang out without pause.

SYSTEM

***Ding! Ding! Ding!* - You defeated Lv. 55 Darkened Orc Warrior! - You gained an extremely small amount of EXP! - You defeated Lv. 83 Darkened Lizard Mage! - You gained an extremely small amount of EXP...**

[1959] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male he is close to.

Then came a cheerful chime I had not heard in a long time.



I could feel it.

My steadily draining internal energy filled to the brim, and the fatigue accumulated throughout my body vanished as if it had been washed away.

But there was something more important.

“Team Leader Choi! Xiao Shen!”

“Yes!”

“What is it?”

I shouted loudly enough for my voice to shake the entire battlefield.

“The fog! Get as far outside its range as you can!”

This was not merely unpleasant, clammy fog. It was a kind of Magic wielded by the Arch Lich.

It strengthened the monsters within its range—or rather, made them *Darkened*.

Damn Magic.

At that very moment, as I glared at the mysterious fog filling the area around me—

Kraaaa-boom!

A thunderous roar, as if the sky itself had split apart, echoed across heaven and earth.

Chapter 411

For a moment, it felt as though the world had stopped.

My instincts reacted before my brain could process the situation.

The breathing of the people around me and the monsters' howls receded into the distance, as if they were coming from several kilometers[1960] away. My senses, sharper than ever, took in every detail around me.

Fwoooosh.

Droplets of blood, dirt, and dust drifted slowly through the air. Fog hung close enough to grasp if I reached out my hand.

And then…

Qi.

I could feel it—the immense movement of qi surrounding an area several hundred meters[1961] in every direction. As a red alarm began blaring in my head, I kicked off the ground and shot upward.

"Get clear—!"

Kraaa-boooom!

A flash of light was followed by a tremendous roar that shook heaven and earth. From more than ten meters[1962] in the air, I looked down over the battlefield.

The area within a radius of several hundred meters[1963], centered on the spot where I had been standing only a few seconds earlier, had been devastated.

Through the lingering fog and billowing dust, I could see green blood coating the ground and monster corpses blown to pieces.

A Magic Trap.

Fighting an enemy who refused to show himself meant preparing for anything.

There's no compassion in war.

The countless wars recorded throughout human history had served as witness, prosecutor, and judge.

Even humans committed all kinds of horrific atrocities against one another during war. Expecting compassion from monsters that weren't even human was laughable.

That was why vigilance was an essential virtue in war. It reduced the chances of falling into an enemy's trap and minimized casualties.

Just like now.

Tap.

[1960] One kilometer is about 0.62 mi.

[1961] One hundred meters is about 328 ft.

[1962] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

[1963] One hundred meters is about 328 ft.

I landed lightly and reached out my hand.

Bang!

Compressed air burst outward, scattering the dust clouds.

Familiar faces finally emerged from among the blood and corpses covering the ground.

“Team Leader Choi.”

Team Leader Choi took a deep breath and nodded. Behind him stood more than two hundred members of the suicide squad, their faces pale with terror.

“A few people are injured…but everyone made it.”

“That’s a relief.”

“It was an unbelievably powerful trap. Without this, most of us—including me—would probably have died.”

Shk. Wooooong.

Team Leader Choi reached out and touched the transparent barrier spread out before him.

It covered every member of the suicide squad—a Barrier spell painstakingly inscribed into a scroll by one of the three greatest mages among billions of people.

“When the battle is over, I should find Mr. Johnson first. His magic saved our lives.”

“Are you planning to thank him with a kiss?”

“At this point, there’s nothing I wouldn’t do.”

Xiao Shen exhaled the breath he had been holding and joined in.

“I’d be willing to go even further. This is truly…”

Unable to finish, he looked around.

The explosion had been that tremendous. By even the roughest estimate, more than a thousand monsters had been killed or rendered incapable of fighting.

A trap that had not distinguished friend from foe. The Arch Lich had thrown countless subordinates into it as kindling to catch me and the suicide squad.

Look at this bastard…

I had expected as much to some extent, but the Arch Lich’s cunning and boldness went beyond anything I had imagined.

If my signal had been even slightly late, or if I had not volunteered to be bait while breaking through the path ahead, every member of the suicide squad would have been buried here.

Just like that day.

A memory I would never forget. A tragedy that could never be allowed to happen again.

I turned and spoke.

“Keep your distance and follow me. Our objective isn’t to fight the monsters. It’s to break through them.”

The suicide squad answered with a thunderous shout.

The monster army, thrown into chaos after suddenly losing so many of its own in the explosion, hesitated and began to retreat.

A crisis had become an opportunity. We couldn't let this momentum slip away.

"Charge!"

I unleashed an azure dragon's roar infused with internal energy and shot forward.

Slash!

The head of a retreating monster flew into the air.

The two hundred members of the suicide squad drove into the gap left in the monster army like an awl. The main force behind them surged forward like a wave.

"Waaaaaaaaah!"

A deafening roar shook the battlefield.

Green blood spread through the fog.

And far above, a flock of crows circled as they watched the battlefield below.

The being sitting atop a throne of white bones, as if asleep, suddenly opened his eyes.

Intense light flared within his empty eye sockets, and a low murmur escaped him.

"Not bad."

The Arch Lich had hundreds of eyes and ears.

Even now, the Familiars he had stationed throughout the battlefield were taking in every detail without missing a thing.

The humans and monsters locked in fierce combat.

And the group of humans rapidly breaking through the battlefield.

The suicide squad. That was what they called them, wasn't it?

The Arch Lich suddenly recalled something.

An ancient, long-moldering memory. One he had been unable to forget despite spending what felt like eternity submerged in the River of Death.

No. One he could never forget.

The Adversary.

How could he forget?

The single human who had stood at the center of everything. The suicide squad that had risked death to charge alongside the Adversary.

That bastard was the one who drove a sword into my body.

The Arch Lich looked down at his body of pitch-black bone.

In the past, he had not been some lowly existence like an undead. He had been a noble and mighty being, trusted by a king and commanding countless monsters.

But on the day of the final battle, he too had fallen alongside his king.

At the hands of a mere human, no less.

“But…where is the Adversary?”

The Arch Lich’s voice was filled with doubt.

He had surveyed every front through his Familiars, yet the Adversary, who should have appeared, was nowhere to be seen. He had found several humans from his memories, but that was all.

Could it be?

The Arch Lich’s eyes flared violently as he realized something.

It was impossible to believe.

But what if—what if the Adversary had died?

What if the Adversary had met the fate of a mortal?

“Kha…khahahaha!”

His body, rigid as a statue, began to shake.

The laughter infused with magical power made the ground tremble and the air quiver.

Sensing the change in their master’s mood, the guards dropped to the ground and prostrated themselves.

“My lord.”

“Why do you laugh so?”

The guards were an impressive sight. Death Knights, each comparable to a Named Monster, stood alongside Liches with robes pulled low over their heads. Altogether, they numbered twenty.

They were creations made to fight the Adversary.

But now, the Arch Lich had changed his mind.

After laughing with delight, the Arch Lich finally spoke.

“Listen, my faithful servants.”

“Give us your command.”

The Arch Lich rose from his seat and looked down upon his loyal retainers. A chilling voice soon echoed through the space.

“Go to the battlefield. Trample those insignificant humans and wipe them out.”

The twenty Death Knights and Liches bowed without the slightest hesitation.

The Arch Lich was the lord of every undead present. There could be no hesitation in obeying his commands.

“We shall carry out our lord’s command.”

They answered in unison and departed in different directions.

The space was empty once more.

Still chuckling to himself, the Arch Lich sat upon his skeletal throne and focused his mind.

He was surveying the battlefield through the eyes and ears of his countless Familiars when he suddenly paused.

“But…what in the world is that human?”

The pitch-black eyes of a crow soaring overhead reflected a young human cutting through monsters amid sprays of blood.

It was a face absent from the Arch Lich’s memories of the past, though he had already seen him through his Familiars several days earlier.

“That’s the human who defeated the Death Knight Lord.”

The Death Knight Lord, created from Lei Fei, was the finest of all the Arch Lich’s creations.

Although Lei Fei’s powerful soul had prevented the Arch Lich from subjugating him completely, there could be no doubting his strength. The Arch Lich had personally bestowed a portion of his own power upon him.

And yet, because of that insignificant human, he had lost his greatest fighting force and wasted precious magical power.

“He irritates me. I should dispose of him properly while I have the chance.”

Having decided to eliminate him, the Arch Lich sent out a thought.

Half of the guards heading toward the various fronts changed direction at their lord’s order.

Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

Wind, weapons, and the bodies of monsters harder than stone.

Everything caught in the spearhead’s path was cut apart.

Heads flew into the air, and thick limbs spun through the sky.

A Troll that was still breathing was chopped to pieces before it had a chance to regenerate. An ogre that had become undead while still half-rotten staggered, only for a sword that came flying a moment later to take off its upper body.

Slash! Slash! Slash!

After cutting down three or four monsters in an instant with Hero’s Soul, Team Leader Choi shouted to me.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung! The monster assault is too strong!”

He was right. Once we broke through the front line, the number of monsters decreased, but those that remained were far stronger.

I knew it would be like this.

The monsters at the front, used as kindling for the Magic Trap meant to catch us, had mostly been mid- or low-level.

The Arch Lich had placed his elites in the rear and used the other monsters as both bait and meat shields.

To wear us down.

On top of that, the fog had grown even thicker, making the battle more difficult.

The monsters becoming stronger under its influence was bad enough, but in fog this thick, visibility was limited and sound didn't carry properly.

That naturally favored monsters, whose senses were sharper than those of humans.

Of course…

I'm the exception.

Whoooosh! Bang!

My spear lashed out with all my strength, skewering six or seven monsters like meat on a skewer.

Xiao Shen and the Hunters in the suicide squad, having escaped the crisis, gave me grateful looks.

"Everyone, group up around me!"

"But we only have a few magic scrolls left. If another Magic Trap activates…"

"No time to explain! Stop talking and move!"

Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen nodded at my shout and advanced with the suicide squad.

I understood their concern, but we had already survived three Magic Traps, and this was the rear where the Arch Lich had gathered his elites. The chances of another trap being triggered were slim.

"Focus on defense instead of attacking. Advance!"

The battle itself had become more difficult, but the reduced chance of suddenly stumbling into another trap took a weight off my mind.

I could get myself out of danger easily enough, but the other members of the suicide squad might not survive.

Our final destination is just ahead. Minimize casualties, then join up with Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing.

Slash! Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

I was at the front, cutting a path through the monsters and beginning to feel fatigue build up, when—

"All. Of. You. Fall. Back!"

"Human. By my lord's command, I shall take your life."

The curtain of monsters split apart to the left and right like the parting of the Red Sea.

I stared blankly, my mouth hanging open, as the beings behind it revealed themselves.

> **System - Lv. 120 Darkened Lich - Lv. 115 Darkened Death Knight**

There were ten of them, all hovering around Level 120.
For a moment, I could barely breathe. My hands and feet began to tremble.
Team Leader Choi shouted at me in a voice filled with despair.
“We have to retreat right now!”
“T-Team Leader Choi.”
“Get a grip, Mr. Jin Taekyung!”
“The lunchboxes are here.”
“If we keep going like this, we’ll be wiped out…huh?”
With trembling eyes, I stared at the ten monsters.
No—the ten lunchboxes.
“The lunchbox delivery is here.”
“…?”
“…?”
“…?”
Put those question marks away, you bastards.
One Annihilation, coming up.

Chapter 412

Flap, flap.

A crow landed on an ancient tree in the middle of the battlefield, its eyes flashing brightly.

The Arch Lich had perched his Familiar in a spot with an excellent view and was watching the situation unfold with considerable pleasure.

What will you do, human?

One person was reflected in the crow's endlessly gleaming black eyes.

An open mouth. Hands trembling slightly.

The sight of Jin Taekyung made the Arch Lich wonder.

Was the Death Knight Lord truly defeated by such a cowardly human?

The Death Knight Lord may have had a few flaws, but he was unquestionably a masterpiece for the ages.

The Arch Lich had been unable to resist coveting Lei Fei, an excellent material with a noble spirit and formidable martial power.

That was why he had personally granted him a portion of the magical power that formed the very source of his strength. Thanks to that gift, Lei Fei had become a being who transcended the limits of an ordinary Death Knight.

There was no way the Death Knight Lord could have fallen to a mere coward.

What exactly happened?

That day, the Arch Lich had not watched Jin Taekyung and Lei Fei's battle to the end. No—he had not thought there was any need to.

By the time the young human arrived, the human army had already been wiped out. The situation on another front had seemed far more important than watching a foregone conclusion play out.

By the time he belatedly sensed the erasure of his precious retainer and sent a Familiar, everything was already over.

All the Arch Lich had seen was Jin Taekyung standing with several thousand humans who had appeared out of nowhere—and the monster army, annihilated to the last.

That human clearly couldn't have done it alone. Was he simply lucky?

But his luck ended here.

As many as ten Death Knights and Liches possessed the strength of an entire legion, if not more.

And unlike last time, he has no one capable of helping him.

There was only one path left for that human now.

He would helplessly watch his companions die, then fall himself.

That was the only possible ending—and the punishment the Arch Lich had chosen for him.

Cawww!

The crow, sharing its master's mood, let out a grating cry.

Step. Step.

At that very moment, the human approaching his retainers without fear came to a halt.

Then he raised a trembling hand toward the Death Knights and Liches radiating immense magical power.

Does he intend to surrender?

The Arch Lich had thought he was merely a coward. He had not expected him to be this stupid as well.

If he believed surrender would persuade the Arch Lich to spare him, he was gravely mistaken—

"One, two, three, four…"

…?

The Arch Lich found himself flustered for the first time in ages.

First, because fluent Demon Realm language had flowed from Jin Taekyung's mouth.

Second, because he had no idea what Jin Taekyung was doing.

What in the world is he up to?

He did not have to wonder for long.

"…Nine, ten."

As soon as he finished speaking, a droplet of saliva fell from Jin Taekyung's chin with a soft *plop*.

He wiped his mouth with his sleeve, a satisfied smile spreading across his face.

"The plating is a work of art. Seriously. I hereby award it three Jin-shelin[1964] stars."

…?

…?

Neither the Arch Lich nor his faithful retainers understood what *plating* or *Jin-shelin* meant.

But they understood what Jin Taekyung's next action meant.

Goooooooong.

The spearhead had already been drawn far back, too fast for the eye to follow. A terrifying torrent of qi gathered around it.

At that sight, the Arch Lich felt a shock as though his cold, hardened heart had dropped into his stomach.

[1964] *Jin-shelin* plays on Michelin's restaurant star rating.

A bone-deep chill swept through him, and his thought burst forth.

Dodge—!

But the spear shot forward faster than the thought could reach his retainers.

Wooooooong!

The wind tore apart.

Kraaaaaaaaaash!

Space split open.

Within an instant divided into ever smaller slivers of time, a massive vortex wreathed in blue flames swallowed everything.

Countless monsters. Death Knights and Liches.

Even the flock of crows perched in an ancient tree nearby, watching it all unfold.

Fwooooooosh!

A blinding flash engulfed everyone's vision.

Whooooooosh.

A wind that had come from somewhere seeped through my entire body.

It was a wind only I could feel—and the arrival of new power.

Yes. That's the stuff.

I smiled at the empty space beyond the slowly fading light.

That was where the Death Knights, Liches, and countless other monsters had been standing.

Everything had been cleanly erased, leaving the air filled with System notifications.

Ding. Ding. Ding…

> **System** - You defeated **Lv. 115 Darkened Death Knight**! - You defeated **Lv. 120 Darkened Lich**! - You defeated **Lv. 122 Darkened Death Knight**! - … - You have defeated too many monsters! - You have gained a massive amount of EXP and Fame! - Level Up! - Level Up! - Level Up! - You have accomplished an exceptional feat! - As a Reward for your achievement, you have obtained the Title **One Against a Thousand**! - Due to the effect of the Title **One Against a Thousand**, all Stats rise by a set amount when facing multiple enemies, and fatigue consumption is greatly reduced! During battle, enemies will be intimidated, while allies' morale rises dramatically! - Because you have accomplished an exceptional feat, a massive amount of EXP and additional Rewards will be granted! - Level Up! - A new stat, **Intimidation**, has been created! - Due to the effect of the Title **One Against**

> **a Thousand**, **Intimidation** has increased significantly! - Enemies who face you will feel fear and terror!

I closed my eyes and savored the lingering rush the System had given me.

A symphony of System notifications chimed without pause.

So this was what the bells of heaven sounded like.

Four Level Ups had completely washed away the fatigue from One Annihilation. I had gained a Title that would be exceptionally effective on a massive battlefield like this, along with a new stat called Intimidation.

What a rush. It never gets old. The System is the best.

If every day were like this, I could die without regrets.

"Is that true? Oh! Ohhh…!"

That fucking bastard.

The Skeleton Warlord's mood-killing remark made me open my eyes. The first thing I saw was a sea of humans and monsters frozen like statues.

"…Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"H-Hyung.[1965]"

Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen stared at me in a daze.

And it wasn't just those two.

All two hundred or so members of the suicide squad looked the same.

Their eyes and voices held unmistakable awe as they gazed at me.

"Good heavens."

"W-What in the world just happened?"

"There were ten Death Knights and Liches. Right there! I saw them with my own eyes!"

Yeah. They had been there.

But now they weren't.

"Goddamn! Holy shit! What the fuck is this? Fucking! Fucking kimchi! Jesus kimchi!"

"Eeeh, eeeeeh? Nani?[1966] Naiii?!"

"…"

Since some of the Hunters had been sent by mercenary companies or the UN, their reactions varied by nationality.

I spoke to Team Leader Choi, who still seemed incapable of forming a sentence.

"Why are you so surprised? It's not like you've never seen it before."

"Was that what you used last time, when you defeated the Black Drake…?"

[1965] *Hyung* is a Korean term a male uses to address an older male with whom he is familiar.

[1966] *Nani* is Japanese for "what?"

"That's right."

Team Leader Choi, who had seen One Annihilation once or twice before, swallowed hard.

"…I don't remember it being this powerful."

"I was holding back then."

That was obviously a lie.

The truth was, even I was so stunned by what I had just done that I had no idea what to say.

The first and only time I had used One Annihilation after reaching the Supreme Peak realm was during my battle with the Western Heaven Demon Lord. I had been so exhausted that I lost consciousness immediately afterward.

I didn't know it would be this powerful either.

There had been ten Death Knights and Liches, each one close to Named level.

I had thought killing six or seven of them would count as a success.

After all, monsters at Level 100 or above gave a considerable amount of EXP. With all the other small fry thrown in, there would be enough to level up, so I'd figured there was no way I'd collapse from exhaustion and make a spectacle of myself.

…But this is even more than I expected.

A double-edged sword.

No—a double-edged spear.

But it was undeniably one hell of a powerful strike.

It had blown away not only the hundreds of elite monsters packed tightly together, but all ten Death Knights and Liches as well.

That left a massive gap in the monster army surrounding the suicide squad and me, and the monsters themselves were visibly confused.

I'd be an idiot to waste an opportunity like this.

I raised my spear without hesitation.

The unexpected turn of events had temporarily brought both sides to a halt. But if the monster army recovered and surrounded the badly outnumbered suicide squad again, there was no telling what would happen.

"What are you waiting for, you bastards?"

"Huh?"

"What?"

"Eeeeeh?"

My shout, charged with internal energy, jolted everyone back to their senses.

There was no time for honorifics or any of that.

Right now, only one thing mattered.

"Wipe out everything in your path!"

"…!"

Ding.

> **System** - Due to the effect of the Title **One Against a Thousand**, the morale of your allies has risen dramatically! Those who follow your command will form a strong bond and fight even more effectively! - Due to the effect of the Title **One Against a Thousand**, the enemy has become greatly intimidated! - Due to the Title **One Against a Thousand**, the effect of **Intimidation** has increased! - Under the influence of **Intimidation**, the enemy feels fear and backs away!

The System messages described exactly what was happening.

The monsters still alive after witnessing the divine might I had displayed slowly retreated. Even the undead monsters, which had already lost their minds, were intimidated and flinched.

As for us?

"Charge!"

Whoosh! Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

With a thunderous shout, I leaped into the gap created by One Annihilation and swung my spear in every direction.

The roughly two hundred members of the suicide squad surged forward as one, roaring loudly enough to make my ears ring.

"Waaaaaaaaah!"

"Follow Mr. Jin! Wipe them all out!"

"Fucking! Fucking Jin Genghis Khan! Jesus Kimchiman!"

"Eeeeeeeh?!"

Splat! Shraaaaaak!

Green blood sprayed through the air, and undead bones shattered into pieces.

Slash!

I cleanly split the upper body of a Troll trying to turn its back and flee.

The Skeleton Warlord shouted at me furiously.

"Wicked human! Over there! Kill that one!"

"What? Who?"

"Kill that strange human who keeps going 'eeeeeeh'!"

"…"

"Or I'll kill him myself! If he does it one more time, I swear I'll kill him!"

"Yeah, okay."

I'd been hearing it too, and it was starting to piss me off.

“Ghk!”

The Arch Lich let out a strangled groan.

As if having the Link with his Familiar forcibly severed were not enough, all ten of his guards had been erased in a single blow.

Unlike ordinary monsters, they were retainers imbued with his own power. The Arch Lich could not escape the backlash.

“This is madness. How could a mere human…”

The Arch Lich gathered his disrupted magical power, then stopped short.

A mere human?

No. That was wrong.

Humans were certainly insignificant beings, but they could never be underestimated.

The Arch Lich had already learned that lesson through bitter experience.

Could that guy…?

At the ominous possibility that flashed through his mind, the light in the Arch Lich’s eyes blazed fiercely.

Chapter 413

Fwoooosh! Kraaaash!

A massive greatsword smashed into the ground. Wu Heixing's body shot upward like lightning, having dodged the attack by exactly half a span.[1967]

Shnk!

His blade drove up beneath the ogre's jaw and burst out through the crown of its head.

A precise strike, without a single wasted motion.

Wu Heixing wrenched his sword free, stepped off the falling ogre's shoulder, and dropped into the horde of monsters.

The sword in his hand traced countless lines through the air.

The Twelve Blood Net Sword.

Some condemned the Cultural Revolution,[1968] which lasted from 1966 to 1976, as an atrocity that outraged heaven and humanity. For others, however, it had been the opportunity of a lifetime.

Wu Heixing's grandfather, a longtime political associate of Mao Zedong,[1969] had risen spectacularly and embezzled an astronomical fortune. Using his son—a member of the Red Guards[1970]—as a stepping stone, he had smuggled away all manner of cultural artifacts and ancient books.

The Twelve Blood Net Sword Wu Heixing had learned was one of the countless ancient books his grandfather had acquired at the time.

Shreeeeek!

A net of twelve strands spread out, covering more than ten meters[1971] in every direction.

The net of red aura sliced through skin and flesh and cleaved bone. Dozens of high-tier monsters fell apart in pieces.

It was power worthy of an S-rank Hunter.

Thoroughly emboldened, Wu Heixing shouted.

"Red Guard Gang! What are you doing? Sweep them all away, you bastards!"

"Yes, sir!"

His mana-infused roar shook the battlefield.

[1967] A *ppyeom* is a handspan, measured between the tips of an outstretched thumb and little finger. Half a span is roughly 10 cm (4 in), though it varies by hand.

[1968] The Cultural Revolution was a political campaign in China that targeted perceived ideological opponents and many cultural traditions.

[1969] Mao Zedong led the People's Republic of China during the Cultural Revolution.

[1970] The Red Guards were radical youth organizations active during China's Cultural Revolution.

[1971] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

The roughly three hundred elite Hunters of the Red Guard Gang, founded by Wu Heixing's family and raised as their private army, charged into every opening without hesitation.

Shreeeek! Splurt!

Whoosh! Slash!

—Krrk, khrrrk!

"Aaaaargh!"

The screams of humans and monsters mingled with sprays of blood on every side.

The Red Guard Gang Hunters whom Wu Heixing had held in reserve until the very end were unquestionably strong. But their enemies were high-tier monsters as well.

The elite monsters positioned in the rear darted through the thick fog as they fought the Hunters. Regardless of the difference in level, the monsters outnumbered them three or four to one.

And yet…

"You filthy, stinking bastards dare!"

Stab-stab-stab!

The presence of an S-rank Hunter like Wu Heixing was enough to turn the unfavorable battle around.

He might have drawn widespread criticism for his debauched behavior and foul temperament, but he was still a genius who had grown up with every possible advantage.

Besides, unlike when he had first been deployed to the front lines, Wu Heixing had become more experienced. After passing through battlefields where death ran rampant, his skills had advanced by another step.

I can do this! I'm Wu Heixing!

Exhilaration surged from deep within his chest as he swung his sword without pause.

His enemy was a monster army numbering in the tens of thousands. He had been afraid at first, but somehow he had made it this far.

Whenever he suffered even a minor injury or began to tire, he gulped down expensive potions like water. When necessary, he had used the Red Guard Gang Hunters as shields to withdraw.

And now, not a single monster could stop his red aura blade.

I'll make sure no one ever looks down on me again. Lei Fei. That fucking bangzi[1972] *bastard. No one!*

That was the moment Wu Heixing ground his teeth at the humiliating memory.

Fwooooooosh! Boom!

[1972] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for a Korean person.

A spear flew in at blinding speed, skewering three or four Hunters like meat on a skewer before burying itself deep in the ground.

A three-meter-long[1973] lance—something rarely seen on a battlefield like this.

Wu Heixing whipped his head around to find the attacker, and his eyes flew wide.

“Death Knight!”

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The figure riding a skeletal horse across the battlefield was unmistakably a Death Knight.

And there were two of them, not one.

The second Death Knight raised its lance from horseback.

“Everyone, watch—!”

Fwooooooosh! Boom!

Before Wu Heixing could finish his warning, the second lance tore through the air and pierced six or seven Hunters clustered together.

Even the finest armor could not stop the strike. Arms and legs flew into the air, and bodies missing their upper halves collapsed with heavy thuds.

The sudden appearance of the Death Knights.

Then, as the Red Guard Gang’s Hunters froze at the horrifying sight unfolding before their eyes—

—D-a-r-k. V-i-n-e!

An eerie voice like metal scraping against metal rang out, and the ground began to change.

Crack! Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

The solid ground split apart like a spiderweb, and black vines surged up through the cracks.

Filled with magical power, they moved like living creatures. Some seized human arms and legs, while others wormed through gaps left exposed by armor and pierced their victims.

Shrrrrk! Stab-stab!

“Kyaaaaargh!”

“Black magic! It’s black magic!”

“Don’t panic! Cut the vines! Get out of the area now!”

Screams and shouts rang out everywhere.

Crack.

Wu Heixing tore the black vines coiling around him from the ground like scallion roots and flung them aside, biting down hard on his lip.

It was not the deaths of his Hunters that troubled him.

[1973] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

He understood what this entire series of events meant.

“Lich…!”

Wu Heixing’s guess was correct.

High above their heads, a death mage riding atop the head of a giant Wyvern that prowled through the gray sky raised a staff made of skulls and bones and pointed it at the ground.

—C-o-n-f-u-s-i-n-g!

Whooooooosh!

With that eerie cry, magical power poured down like dark storm clouds and engulfed the entire area.

The Hunters struggling to escape the black vines suddenly writhed as hallucinations and phantom voices seized them. They became easy prey for the monsters lurking around them.

—Sssssss!

—Gwoooooar!

Smash! Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

“Krrk, khk!”

“P-Please, save me!”

“Mother! You can’t die, Mother!”

Some fell with a final scream.

Others continued to howl even as they died, unable to escape the hallucinations and phantom voices.

But there were also those whose powerful wills allowed them to break free of the spell.

“You have to go!”

“Young Master!”

Despite the shouts of the A-rank Hunters surrounding him, Wu Heixing’s face had gone as white as a sheet.

Only one question circled through his mind.

What—what the hell am I supposed to do?

The Lich was in the sky, while two Death Knights were rapidly approaching from the ground.

Could they retreat?

If they did, where would they go? How would they get there?

Wu Heixing might have been able to face the two Death Knights alone, but what about the Lich’s magic and the countless monsters surrounding the area so tightly that not even water could pass through?

No matter how hard he thought, he could find no answer.

This…this fucking situation…

Crack.

Wu Heixing was grinding his teeth hard enough to crack them when—

Fwoooosh! Bang!

With the sharp crack of compressed air exploding, a streak of light shot up from the distant ground and sliced through the sky.

The next moment, the headless body of the Wyvern began to plummet.

“This…”

Wu Heixing muttered the word like a groan.

Everyone forgot the situation around them and looked up at the sky.

Before their eyes, the Wyvern’s body plummeted faster and faster, while a heap of black bones—the being that had once been called a Lich—tumbled down after it.

“…That’s impossible.”

The Lich was dead.

Killed in a single strike.

Someone had pierced through dozens of layers of defensive magic and accurately intercepted a target in midair?

Even an S-rank Hunter could not easily guarantee such a feat.

Wu Heixing had never seen an attack so fast or so powerful.

But for someone else, it was as natural as breathing.

The man who had been quietly watching what he had done from a short distance away suddenly opened his mouth.

“It’s been a long time since I threw a spear. I’m certainly not as good as I used to be.”

The man standing behind him like an iron tower answered in a stiff tone.

“It was an excellent throw.”

“Hmm. No, it wasn’t. I seem to have grown rusty. Proof that I’m getting old, I suppose.”

“That cannot be.”

At the Head of Security’s usual flat response, Lee Jungryong smiled gently.

“I saw Death Knights.”

Go Jun nodded without a word.

“Yes. Two of them.”

“Do you think Wu Heixing can stop them?”

“If you mean the Death Knights, he should be able to defeat them without much difficulty.”

Go Jun added in a low voice.

“If there were no monsters around them.”

“So under the present circumstances, it will be difficult.”

“The black magic has dissipated, but they have already suffered considerable losses, and there are far too many monsters.”

“Then they’ll have to struggle with everything they have.”

“It will be a fierce and difficult battle.”

“My, my. Then I suppose we should help them.”

“Would it not be better to watch a little longer?”

Lee Jungryong widened his eyes in feigned surprise.

“Why?”

Go Jun had been taught by Lee Jungryong since childhood. He knew that each of these moments was a test from his Master.

He also knew what answer was expected of him.

“Would they not be more grateful if we helped them when the situation was more precarious?”

Only then did the Master smile in satisfaction at his Disciple’s answer. Even his manner of speaking changed.

“Yes. That’s exactly it.”

“The Red Guard Gang has been a nuisance for some time.”

“They’re amusing bastards. They shout about the people and communism, then form a private army of Hunters behind everyone’s backs.”

“But the Crown Prince Party supporting the Red Guard Gang is friendly toward us, is it not?”

“That is precisely why the Red Guard Gang must disappear. They have always avoided the sunlight by sitting in the shade of that tree. Once the tree is uprooted, what choice will they have?”

“They’ll have to find another tree or buy themselves a parasol.”

“We will become their new tree. If that happens, even more opportunities will open up.”

Go Jun nodded, then suddenly spoke.

“May I ask one more question?”

“Go ahead.”

“The reason you brought Wu Heixing into this operation… Does it have something to do with Jin Taekyung?”

The question had been troubling Go Jun for some time.

Even if Wu Heixing was an S-rank Hunter, why bring along an idiot like him?

That man is immensely powerful. Even if Master is using Wu Heixing, what use could he possibly be?

Sometimes, this happened.

Just when Go Jun thought he had grown accustomed to his Master's thoughts and actions, he would find himself unable to understand Lee Jungryong's true intentions.

And whenever that happened, Lee Jungryong would always wear an inscrutable smile.

Just like now.

"Team Leader Seok."

Both his tone and the atmosphere changed.

Returning to his role as Ares Guild's Head of Security, Go Jun bowed deeply.

"Yes, Vice Guild Master."

"It seems the time has come for you to step in. What do you think?"

Go Jun raised his head and looked past Lee Jungryong's shoulder at the fierce battle.

The carefully selected elites of the Red Guard Gang were dying to the monsters, while Wu Heixing had just finished taking down one of the two Death Knights.

"I'll be going, then."

"Do be careful not to get hurt."

Go Jun answered with a brief bow, then led the waiting Ares Guild members toward the battlefield.

They did not shout as they charged the monsters, but the force they radiated was more than enough to overwhelm everything before them.

Kra-d-d-d-d-k! Slash!

Lee Jungryong watched in satisfaction as one flank of the monster army collapsed in an instant.

Then he suddenly caught the smell of blood carried on the wind.

The wind was blowing from the west.

It was the signal that the man he had been waiting for had arrived.

"Right on time."

Lee Jungryong murmured under his breath and looked toward the distant horizon.

As he raised his qi, his senses sharpened like a razor, and a man's shout reached his ears.

—Fuck, kill them all! And that bastard who's been going 'Eeeeeeh' this whole time —if he does it one more time, I'm counting him as a monster. Got it?

Lee Jungryong let out a low chuckle and extended his hand.

Then he clenched his fist toward Jin Taekyung, who was somewhere out there.

Chapter 414

Some faces are never a welcome sight, no matter how many times you see them. For me, Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing fell squarely into that category.

Even so, I spoke first because Wu Heixing looked almost presentable today.

“Fancy seeing you here. I thought I’d never see you again.”

At my cheerful greeting, the battered Wu Heixing shot me a venomous glare.

“Shut up.”

“Oh…”

“Say one more word, and on my grandfather’s honor, I’ll tear you limb from limb.”

Is he some Chinese version of Kindaichi or something?[1974] I could never understand why people like him treated their late grandfathers’ honor like a credit card.

I put on a serious face.

“Were you and your grandfather not on good terms?”

“What?”

“No, think about it. Why stake your grandfather’s honor on something impossible? You’d be much better off staking it on you getting torn limb from limb…”

“You fucking bastard!”

Wu Heixing sprang to his feet with an enraged shout, but Lee Jungryong raised a hand to stop him.

“That’s enough.”

“Mr. Lee! But this bastard…”

“Fighting among ourselves before the final battle will do us nothing but harm. Calm down.”

Crunch.

Wu Heixing ground his teeth as if he meant to break them, then glared at me.

“Understood. Since you insist, Mr. Lee, I’ll let it end here.”

“A wise decision.”

Was he really the type to back down so obediently?

As I studied Lee Jungryong’s gentle smile, I turned my head slightly.

A brief glance from Team Leader Choi told me plenty.

“What about you, Jin Taekyung?”

I looked away from Team Leader Choi and gave a casual shrug.

“When an elder speaks, you have to listen.”

“I didn’t know you cared about things like that.”

“You have to respect your elders, don’t you?”

[1974] Kindaichi is a fictional Japanese detective known for vowing to solve mysteries on his grandfather’s name.

At my calm, unruffled answer, Lee Jungryong gave a hearty laugh whose meaning I could not decipher. Wu Heixing glared at me as if he wanted to kill me all over again.

"Respect your elders? Spare me that ridiculous bullshit. Then what about me? I'm seven years older than you."

"If you don't want to write your will, start by making your eyes look nicer."

"You turtle-dicked son of a…!"

"Quit your bullshit."

Wu Heixing's second outburst died in his throat.

I fixed him with a cold stare and continued.

"If you still have enough energy to lose your temper over something this trivial, go check on the friends you brought with you."

"…!"

"They risked their lives to follow you this far. They're not consumables you can use once and throw away."

I made no attempt to hide my contempt.

Barely fifty Hunters remained around Wu Heixing.

According to the report from headquarters, his suicide squad had set out five hundred strong. Most of them must have died or fallen behind.

"Losses? Sure, that happens. We're in the middle of a battle. But…"

Wu Heixing's armor might have been drenched in blood, but it was otherwise completely intact. Even as his comrades died around him, he had fought while protecting himself.

"Got anything to say, you fucking idiot?"

A line from an old superhero movie I had watched as a kid came to mind.

With great power comes great responsibility.

And that didn't apply only to people bitten by radioactive spiders.

If someone could produce an aura blade instead of spiderwebs—if he had used that power to amass tremendous wealth and fame and cover up the crimes he had committed—then he had to bear at least some responsibility.

That was what I believed.

"You might be S-rank, but you're no Hunter. So from now on, when you introduce yourself, don't call yourself one. Just say, 'I'm Wu Heixing, the lucky S-rank.' Got it?"

"…"

Wu Heixing's clenched fists trembled, but Lee Jungryong answered in his place.

"He did his best."

"Judging by his armor, I doubt it. He could wipe that down right now and list it on

Junggonara as used equipment."[1975]

"Wearing sturdy, high-quality armor is hardly grounds for criticism."

"I noticed this last time too, but you go out of your way to defend him. Does that bastard have some kind of dirt on you?"

"Everyone has weaknesses. I simply happen to be quite good at hiding mine."

"You should have your computer checked. Who knows? Maybe Chinese hackers are sharing videos of the Vice Guild Master watching porn in a group chat."

"I'll keep that in mind."

He really is a formidable opponent.

Lee Jungryong smiled without the slightest sign of agitation, but the man standing behind him reacted differently.

I waved at the man radiating a faint killing intent.

"Well, look who it is. Team Leader Seok. Isn't that our Go Jun?"

Lee Jungryong's Head of Security and Disciple.

I distinctly remembered beating him half to death before we left for China, but the man standing before me looked not only fine, but even more solid than before.

His gaze alone had grown deeper and more profound. I could tell at a glance that his abilities had advanced significantly.

And he's learned some patience.

Go Jun was the most loyal of all the loyal hounds Lee Jungryong had raised.

In the past, he would have rushed at me without hesitation. But this time, he had gathered up his killing intent until not a trace remained and chosen silence instead of drawing his weapon.

Lee Jungryong regarded his Disciple with satisfaction before speaking.

"We've reached the Arch Lich's doorstep. According to the coordinates, only twenty kilometers remain."[1976]

I swept back my blood-sticky hair.

"Probably the longest and fiercest twenty kilometers on Earth."[1977]

"Indeed. The Arch Lich has kept a considerable force in reserve."

"How many?"

"An estimated fifty thousand."

The moment those words left his mouth, a groan escaped from the members of the suicide squad who had been listening intently to our conversation.

The suicide squads led by Lee Jungryong, Wu Heixing, and me numbered only around five hundred in total.

[1975] Junggonara is a Korean online marketplace for secondhand goods.
[1976] Twenty kilometers is about 12 miles.
[1977] Twenty kilometers is about 12 miles.

The mere estimate was enough to fill them with despair. To reach the Arch Lich, we would have to break through an army a hundred times our size.

Perhaps that was why someone shouted in a frightened voice.

“We should retreat while we still can!”

As if a dam had burst, cries rose from the other Hunters.

“Fuck!”

“There are too many monsters!”

“We’ll all be wiped out if we keep this up!”

“I came here to defeat the Arch Lich, not to die a meaningless death!”

Even the roughly two hundred members of the Western Front’s suicide squad, who had made it this far with almost no losses, were no exception.

Yet amid the fear spreading like wildfire, two people remained unshaken.

Xiao Shen, who watched me with unwavering trust, and…

“There’s a possibility.”

Team Leader Choi had gone beyond simply trusting me. He had independently deduced one possible explanation for the situation. He continued in a calm voice.

“An estimated fifty thousand is far beyond the High Command’s prediction.”

“Then shouldn’t we obviously retreat?”

Team Leader Choi immediately shook his head at the shout from one of the suicide squad members.

“The number of monsters we faced was also lower than expected.”

“Huh?”

“There were certainly many of them, but the monster forces we encountered on the front lines were not as overwhelming as we anticipated.”

“Then…”

“The Arch Lich may have been guarding against precisely this situation. Rather than commit all its forces to the front lines, it kept an army of fifty thousand in reserve as a final move it could use under any circumstances.”

The faces of the Hunters watching Team Leader Choi stiffened—not because they fully understood what he meant, but because the ground beneath their feet had begun to shake with increasing force.

Grk. Gr-r-r-r-rk.

The rumbling could be felt from dozens of kilometers away.[1978] Everyone’s body trembled with it.

A ruined road stretched ahead, vast plains spreading out on either side. Beyond the dense fog filling the landscape, the roars and footsteps of tens of thousands of monsters merged into a faint, distant thunder.

[1978] Dozens of kilometers means a distance of at least roughly 15 miles.

“Groooooooar!”

“This is insane…”

“Run. We have to run. We can’t win this.”

People began to edge backward.

The only exception was the Ares Guild members, who stood firm without wavering. In front of them, Lee Jungryong watched Team Leader Choi with interest.

“So?”

Their gazes met. I saw Team Leader Choi’s grip tighten around **Hero’s Soul**.

“Although the High Command’s prediction was wrong, the front lines must have had forces to spare because the Arch Lich did not launch an all-out attack.”

“Even so, our forces were still insufficient compared to the enemy’s.”

“That is exactly why certain people were left behind—to make up the difference.”

Grk. Gr-r-r-rk.

The vibrations and roars grew stronger. Amid the anxious, agitated murmuring, Team Leader Choi’s mana-charged voice pierced everyone’s ears.

“Those capable of overturning the course of a battle in an instant. S-rank Hunters, each of whom is called a one-person army.”

At that exact moment—

Fwooooooosh!

A dazzling mass of light erupted above our heads.

Amid the brilliant radiance, the air split apart as if sliced by a razor-sharp sword. Three people descended through the opening, stepping on the empty air as though walking down a staircase.

“When I was a child, my great-grandmother would often sit me on her lap and tell me that royalty must fulfill the duties befitting their station. Commoners like you would not understand, of course.”

I let out a snort and bowed at the waist. He was usually annoying beyond belief, but this time I had no choice but to play along.

“His Highness Prince Felix.”

“It is pleasing to hear those words from your lips, Jin, Hunter of the Orient.”

At Prince Felix’s lofty, self-important manner, the beautiful woman beside him clicked her tongue.

“Can’t you do something about him? Gag him, at least.”

“I think we should indulge him today, big sis.”

“Oh my.”

Faye Chen’s eyes widened at my answer, then she broke into a bright smile.

“That’s nice to hear. Coming all this way was worth it after all. Don’t you agree?”

The last of the three laughed heartily at Faye Chen’s question.

"Does that mean I can expect something too? What do you think, Jin?"

"What, should I kiss you?"

"Oh, that wouldn't be bad. But I'll politely decline. I'm already married to my beloved Fred, and we have five adopted children."

Fwoosh. Thump.

Magic Johnson glided down through the air and patted my shoulder with a palm as large as a pot lid.

"Jin, you brave little rascal. How did you ever think of attempting such a dangerous Teleport? I nearly gave up several times."

"But you still did it, Johnson."

"The odds were different. This time, there was only a ten percent chance of failure. You're at least eighty percent braver than I am."

Courage didn't come in sizes.

Simply by risking death to come here, they had proved themselves worthy of being called the greatest Hunters in the world.

The people who had received these unexpected reinforcements stared at them with wide, disbelieving eyes.

"F-Faye Chen?"

"Prince Felix and Magic Johnson are here too!"

"They're S-rank Hunters! S-rank Hunters came to help us!"

"I love you, Johnson! Fucking nice gay!"

But that wasn't the end.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

Another vibration came through the ground, different from the one we had felt moments earlier.

It heralded the arrival of an enormous army marching in step. Far away, countless figures emerged as a line of dots stretching across the distant horizon.

"Did you think we came charging in without a plan?"

Faye Chen grinned.

"Ten thousand troops from the Western and Eastern Fronts combined. That should at least buy enough time for you to escape."

A dazed voice slipped from someone's lips.

"Now we can survive…"

A voice answered him.

"No."

Team Leader Choi raised **Hero's Soul** high.

Even through the dense fog, its transparent blade shone beautifully.

"We're going to win."

I believed it too.

Chapter 415

The battle came quickly.

Before tens of thousands of monsters and the thick fog rolling over the wasteland like waves, a black-skinned Grand Mage stood tall, stepping on empty air, and uttered a single word heralding the beginning of the battle.

“Fire Cannon.”

Fwooooooosh.

An immense torrent of mana swirled around him. Five flames sprang to life in midair, swelled to enormous size, and shot forward like cannonballs.

Fwooooooosh—BOOM!

The black tide of tens of thousands of monsters split apart. Blistering heat burned flesh and bone and melted the ground.

An area-of-effect spell that reduced at least a thousand soldiers to ash.

But the monsters did not stop.

Neither did Magic Johnson.

“Water Blaster.”

The air, dry as sand after the Fire Cannon, grew heavy with moisture.

Magic Johnson spread his arms, and an enormous wave rose behind him.

The sight defied every law of the world.

It was magic in the truest sense—the supernatural power of the greatest War Mage among countless mages.

“Engulf them.”

The cheerful, ever-laughing man was nowhere to be seen.

Magic Johnson flung both hands out, his gaze grave. A wave dozens of meters[1979] high cast a broad, dark shadow over the tens of thousands of monsters.

Roooooar!

Brimming with mana, the wave crashed down. The tremendous water pressure crushed the monsters, bursting their bodies and tearing them apart.

The flames left behind by Fire Cannon went out, and the surrounding area was flooded with water.

Magic Johnson knew exactly what to do next.

“Strike. Lightning Rain.”

It happened in an instant.

Black storm clouds gathered over the monsters’ heads, and dozens of bolts of lightning came crashing down.

BOOM! Crackle!

[1979] Dozens of meters means tens of meters; 10 m is about 33 ft.

—Kraaaaaaar!

—Kyaaak!

The lightning struck without distinction, tearing through targets both in the air and on the ground.

Blackened Gargoyles and Griffins plummeted from the sky, while the ground, soaked by Water Blaster, carried the current.

The living monsters trembled violently and dropped to their knees with a single shriek. The undead collapsed into piles of ash.

At the unbelievable sight unfolding before our eyes, a groan escaped someone's lips.

"So this is a Grand Mage…"

The results of only three area-of-effect spells were staggering.

At least several thousand monsters had either died or been rendered incapable of fighting, and one flank of the monster army had collapsed.

But even the Grand Mage who had single-handedly unleashed a natural disaster could not escape the crushing fatigue.

"Fuck. If I'd known this would happen, I would've saved a few more spells."

Casting magic was no simple task. Area-of-effect magic in particular—Magic Johnson's specialty—consumed mental strength and mana on a scale proportionate to its destructive power.

Considering how much magic he had already poured into the front lines before coming here, this was his limit.

"Mrs. Chen. I guess I'm getting old too."

"Move aside. We old folks have to look out for each other. And…"

Faye Chen tossed aside the whiskey bottle in her hand, drew the bow strapped at her side with lightning speed, and pulled back the string.

An arrow of mana formed against the empty bowstring.

"It's not Mrs. Chen. It's Miss Chen. Who decided I was married?"

Faye Chen snorted and released the string.

The mana arrow, scattering a dazzling radiance, shot forward with a sharp whistle. It erased the space in its path and split through the thick fog.

And then—

BOOM!

A tremendous explosion erupted.

After confirming that the Death Knight hiding among the countless monsters had vanished without even managing a final cry, Faye Chen pulled back her bowstring again.

Thrum-thrum-thrum!

Arrows loosed in the blink of an eye became streaks of light across the wasteland. Thunderous explosions followed, each arrow sweeping away and annihilating dozens of monsters.

If Magic Johnson was one of the world's three greatest Grand Mages and its finest War Mage, Faye Chen was the finest archer alive.

But…

—Gwooooooar!

—Kyaaaaa!

The monster army, tens of thousands strong, ignored it all and charged.

Cut down dozens, and dozens more filled their places. Cut down hundreds, and hundreds more took their place.

Charging through the thick fog, they were stronger and more ferocious than ordinary monsters.

All that remained was an unavoidable head-on battle.

Facing the oncoming monster army, two men stepped forward at the same time.

"Ares Guild. Formation B. Break through them."

Clatter-clatter-clatter!

At Lee Jungryong's quiet command, the elite Guild members who had made it this far without a single casualty moved as one.

Jin Taekyung studied them closely, then addressed the suicide squad he had brought from the Western Front.

"Everyone, Formation J."

"Yes, sir!"

"Formation J! Get into position!"

The suicide squad moved swiftly, repeating the command in thunderous voices.

Behind Jin Taekyung, Wu Heixing had been gathering the handful of Red Guard Gang Hunters who remained. He grabbed one of the Western Front suicide-squad members and asked,

"Hey, rookie. What the hell is Formation J?"

Recognizing Wu Heixing, Xiao Shen frowned before answering.

"Hyung[1980] came up with the formation himself."

"So what does it mean?"

"Nothing special. He said it means, 'Just fucking fight.'"

"…"

Wu Heixing was momentarily speechless, and Lee Jungryong and Jin Taekyung launched themselves forward at the exact same time, as if they had planned it.

Prince Felix and ten thousand Hunters surged fiercely after them.

[1980] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or older man.

“Aaaaaaaaah!”

—Kraaaaaaaargh!

Humans and monsters.

Monsters and humans.

Deafening battle cries and killing intent erupted. Racing across the wasteland at blinding speed, the two sides bared their teeth and leveled their spears and blades at one another.

Fwooooooosh—Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

The great battle had begun.

I leaned back and put my shoulder into it. The movements flowed seamlessly together as I whipped my arm forward with all my strength.

Whoosh—thud-thud-thud-thud!

White Flame shot from my hand, piercing dozens of monsters and opening a path.

A gap appeared in an instant.

Without hesitation, I plunged into it and lashed out with my arms and legs at everything within reach.

Crack!

My fist shot forward too fast to see, crushing the head of the charging Lycanthrope like a watermelon.

Before the brain matter spilling from its skull could hit the ground, I leaped into the air.

Tap—whoosh!

A four-meter-tall[1981] figure loomed before me. My reflection appeared in its pale pupils, long since drained of light.

But before the Undead Troll could swing its club, my palm slammed into its chest.

Boom!

Smoke curled from the Undead Troll’s seven apertures[1982] along with a surge of tremendous heat. Its insides had suffered catastrophic damage, and it met its final death before its extraordinary regenerative power could even come into play.

“Wicked human! Behind you!”

I know, idiot. Who asked for your advice?

I turned my head. A lance wreathed in pitch-black magic grazed my neck and hurtled into the sky.

[1981] Four meters is about 13 ft.

[1982] The traditional seven bodily apertures are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

It had been thrown to catch me while I was suspended in midair. The timing was good, but the enemy had made one mistake.

It had underestimated me.

"Fuck. Why are there so many Death Knights? What is this, a chicken joint?[1983]"

I landed lightly after evading the lance, and a Death Knight mounted on a skeletal horse charged straight at me.

"This. Is. As. Far. As. You. Go!"

Fwooooooosh!

With that shout, it swung a sword wreathed in ominous magic. The energy it gave off could not compare to an S-rank Hunter's, but it was on par with that of a top-tier A-rank Hunter.

Or perhaps…

This Death Knight must have been a Hunter once too.

Maybe that was why.

The sight of the Death Knight reminded me of Lei Fei, leaving a sudden bitter taste in my mouth.

The Skeleton Warlord screamed when it saw my reaction.

"Dodge, human!"

Thud!

The magic clinging to the Death Knight's sword vanished without a trace.

The Death Knight stared blankly at the transparent spearhead that had pierced through its chest and emerged from its back. Then it muttered weakly,

"How…"

"This is as far as you go."

I returned the Death Knight's own words to it and brought down the edge of my hand.

"I don't know who you used to be, but you've suffered enough."

Slash—thud!

The skeletal horse and Death Knight split in two and vanished.

As before, I used Seizing an Object Through Empty Space to draw White Flame back toward me, cutting down a monster along the way. Then I abruptly asked,

"How come you're not pestering me for food today?"

"Ahem. What do you take me for? How dare you mistake this commander for—"

Slash!

"A freeloader. You call yourself a pacifist, but you only start drooling at times like this. Shameless bastard."

[1983] Fried-chicken restaurants are famously everywhere in South Korea, so "a chicken joint" is shorthand for something found on every corner.

"What did you say?"

"Why? Was any of that wrong?"

"You, wicked human, agreed that I should not participate in the battle! And were you not the one who said the other humans could not find out about me?"

"Quit making excuses. So, are you going to absorb that mana or not?"

"…"

Crack!

"Hey. You hear me?"

"Hmm. I don't particularly want to absorb it."

"…What?"

Fwooooooosh!

I was so startled that I nearly let an attack through.

I swept my spear in a wide arc, wiping out a dozen monsters, then asked in all seriousness,

"What's wrong? Is it time for you to vanish?"

"Hmm… I do not know either. I simply feel that way."

"You feel that way?"

"Yes. I am undead too. Sometimes even I feel unsettled. Leave me be."

"…Since when do the undead feel unsettled?"

Normally, he would have charged in like a Beggars' Sect disciple who had not eaten in four days. Why was he acting like this?

Can undead go through puberty too?

Even for an oddball monster like the Skeleton Warlord, that made no sense.

I gave up trying to figure him out and continued cutting down monsters.

That was when it happened.

Roooooooar!

Aura—no, Sword Energy—blanketed a radius of more than ten meters.[1984]

One person landed lightly at the center of the front line, now suddenly empty.

"There are too many monsters. We can't clear a path for the entire suicide squad."

I knew exactly what Lee Jungryong meant.

"You're saying we should go with a small elite force?"

"Precisely. Duck."

I bent backward at Lee Jungryong's warning. A crescent of Sword Energy flew over me and sliced three or four enormous monsters apart like cheesecake.

What if that Sword Energy had been aimed at me? If Lee Jungryong and I fought…

"You, me, and Wu Heixing. The three of us should be enough."

I licked my dry lips before answering.

[1984] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

“That’s a strange thing to say.”

“What is?”

“You never know until you fight. We won’t know how strong the Arch Lich is until we face it.”

“There are three S-rank Hunters here. No matter how powerful the Arch Lich may be, it cannot stand against us.”

Us…

It was a wonderful word. So why did I dislike the way it felt rolling off my tongue?

Maybe it was because of the people included in it.

But I had already made up my mind when I proposed the suicide-squad operation. In that sense, Lee Jungryong’s suggestion was the best option.

“Let’s do that. Where’s Wu Heixing?”

Kra-d-d-d-d-k!

Before I had even finished speaking, Wu Heixing tore his way through the monsters and appeared.

Unlike Lee Jungryong, who remained so immaculate that it was hard to believe he was in the middle of a battle, Wu Heixing looked terrible. But the fierce light in his eyes proved he still had plenty of strength left.

“Good. You made it in time.”

Wu Heixing let out a ragged breath. “Mere monsters could never stop me.”

Didn’t that bastard nearly die to those same mere monsters about an hour ago?

I was inwardly clicking my tongue at how little Wu Heixing had changed when a shout came from far away.

“Mr. Jin!”

It was Team Leader Choi.

Beyond the hundreds of monsters between us, his face briefly appeared before vanishing again.

Then something gleaming spun through the air and embedded itself in the ground nearby.

This is…

I recognized it immediately.

It was **Hero’s Soul**.

From somewhere beyond my sight, Team Leader Choi shouted,

“I’m not going to say I’ll go with you, so take that sword with you instead. And… be careful!”

Those words carried a great deal of meaning.

Without a word, I pulled **Hero’s Soul** from the ground.

Beyond the countless monsters still filling my vision, I could see a city shrouded in darkness.

“Let’s go.”
Lee Jungryong smiled gently.

Chapter 416

Breaking through a fierce battlefield where an army numbering in the tens of thousands was locked in combat was nearly impossible.

But…

“Rage, Blizzard!”

“Johnson, aren’t you pushing yourself too hard? If you keep this up, I can’t just stand by either.”

If the war hero of the Great Cataclysm and the world’s greatest War Mage and archer unleashed devastating area-of-effect magic and arrows like bolts of lightning…

“For Her Majesty the Queen!”

“Long live the Queen!”

If an S-rank Hunter who had appeared like a comet—the prince of the United Kingdom—led the kingdom’s elite royal knights into a charge…

“Formation J! Wipe them all out!”

“Just fucking fight!”

“Yeeeeeeah! Let’s gooo!!!”

And if the hundreds of suicide squad members who had come this far prepared to make the ultimate sacrifice advanced as one…

Roooooar!

Crack-crack! Slash!

A path opened.

A path meant for only three people.

It was the final path to ending this war, and they crossed through tens of thousands of monsters like a streak of light.

Shraaaaaaash!

A dazzling storm of light erupted from two swords and a single spear, sweeping through the monsters.

The head of a Lycanthrope baring its sharp fangs shot into the air, while the limbs of a six-meter-tall[1985] boss monster, a Twin-Headed Ogre, were torn from its body.

Five Death Knights, each commanding a legion, appeared to block their way, but it made no difference.

—In. The. Name. Of. Our. Lord.

—Let. Death. Descend.

Jin Taekyung tossed out a casual remark.

“Two, two, one. Sound good?”

[1985] Six meters is about 19.7 ft.

Lee Jungryong nodded.

“Let’s do that.”

“Wait. What the—!”

Before Wu Heixing could finish objecting, the other two had already dashed forward.

They closed the distance in only two steps, then swung their sword and spear without hesitation.

Boom!

The first exchange. The Death Knight staggered after blocking the whip-like arc of Force.

Its eyes widened as its magic-infused sword shattered into pieces.

—How…!

Boom! Crunch!

The second exchange. The third. And then—

Slash!

A single lightning-fast strike that signaled the end.

The upper half of the Death Knight’s body, armor and all, slowly slid away. Beneath its low-pulled helmet, the light in its eyes flickered like a candle in the wind, then vanished.

Before the bodies of the Death Knights they had each taken responsibility for even touched the ground, Jin Taekyung and Lee Jungryong were already charging toward another enemy.

“Damn it! I’m here too!”

Wu Heixing joined them a moment later.

The fate of the three remaining Death Knights was as good as sealed.

The monsters that witnessed their commanders’ destruction instinctively recoiled in fear.

More. More. More.

Slash! Shraaaaaash!

Jin Taekyung cut and smashed his way through everything around him as he advanced. Then, at some point, he realized it.

They’re gone.

The monsters that had endlessly blocked their path were nowhere to be seen. Only a ruined road and vast plains stretching out on either side remained.

At the end of the road, a city shrouded in thick fog awaited them.

Lee Jungryong, Wu Heixing, and I raced toward the city where the Arch Lich was.

—Wicked human. This commander has a long-held wish.

What is it?

—To return to my homeland and enjoy a peaceful life.

You don't even remember where your homeland is.

—…How could you say something so cruel?

Ah, sorry. I didn't mean it like that. So where is your homeland?

—The first place where I regained consciousness. Korea. I have decided to make it the homeland of my heart.

"…"

I faltered as I ran toward the city.

Is he insane?

A monster trying to obtain citizenship. An undead illegal immigrant who had slipped into the country through a Gate, yet he had no shortage of things to say. His reasons for going this far were obvious, of course.

—So please, let's turn back.

I don't want to.

—My head has felt dizzy and my stomach has been churning for a while now.

That's strange. The more I talk to you, the more I think I'm developing similar symptoms.

—It isn't too late yet! Please stop! If we go in there, there really will be no turning back!

No.

It's already too late.

I muttered the words inwardly and took another step.

As we entered the city, the first things to greet us were the ominously thick fog and frigid air.

At the same time, a familiar energy I had felt countless times before—yet somehow different—brushed across my entire body.

"This is…"

Sticky and unpleasant. It did not take me long to realize what the energy was, and Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing reached the same conclusion.

"Mr. Lee…"

"Yes. I see."

Lee Jungryong swept his surroundings with a somber gaze, then spoke.

"It's a Gate. I wondered where so many monsters were pouring out from. Now we know why."

Lee Jungryong's guess was wrong.

Or rather, it would be more accurate to say he was half right.

I gave a small shake of my head and corrected him.

“I don’t think the Gate transformation is complete yet.”

Wu Heixing swallowed hard.

“How do you know that?”

“Just a feeling.”

“What?”

“If you don’t believe me, never mind.”

“…What kind of person says something like that?”

As expected, Wu Heixing looked dumbfounded. Lee Jungryong, however, reacted differently.

His gaze held a clear mixture of suspicion and surprise.

“How did you know?”

“You already knew?”

“I only just realized it. I felt this same sensation a very long time ago, in North America during the Great Cataclysm.”

“I see.”

“But this phenomenon hasn’t occurred even once since the Great Cataclysm. How did you know?”

“As I said, it’s just a feeling. I had a hunch.”

“A hunch…”

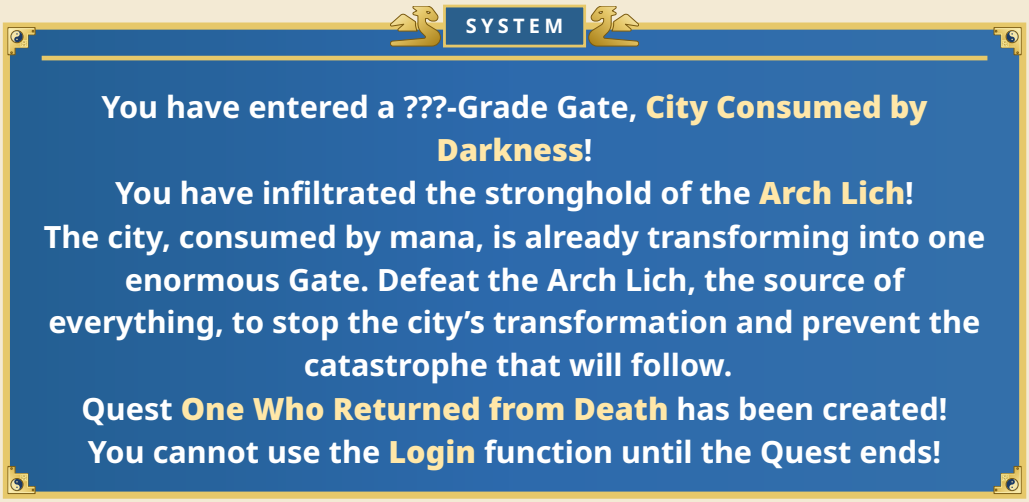
Lee Jungryong studied me with an unreadable expression after my firm answer.

But that was all I could say. Even if I told him the truth, he would not be able to understand it anyway.

It’s not as if I can show him the System window.

I raised my head and glanced at the empty air. A System message had appeared before my eyes the instant we entered the city.

Ding.



Gate transformation.

It was a phenomenon from the past that I had only ever read about in textbooks.

Lee Jungryong gazed beyond the thick fog and spoke.

"Gate transformations were rare even during the Great Cataclysm. For one to occur, an extremely powerful monster must serve as its core and put down roots with its mana."

There was no need to wonder which extremely powerful monster that might be.

I blurted out its name.

"The Arch Lich."

"Yes. It has to be the Arch Lich. It must be contaminating the city with mana and turning it into one enormous Gate. That must also be why it has not appeared on the battlefield until now."

Nearly two hundred thousand monsters had appeared on the battlefield so far.

That alone was a catastrophe of staggering proportions. But if the Gate transformation were completed…

We're finished.

Humanity would undoubtedly emerge victorious in the end, but countless cities would be destroyed, and hundreds of thousands—no, perhaps millions—of people would die.

We had to stop it before it was too late.

"We don't have much time. We need to hurry."

Lee Jungryong nodded.

"We should avoid the monsters whenever possible. We'll need to conserve every bit of strength we can before facing the Arch Lich. Mr. Wu, that includes you."

"…Yes."

We began moving through the thick fog.

Unlike the small city where I had fought Lei Fei last time, this place—the Arch Lich's stronghold—covered more than ten times the area and still bore traces of having once been a bustling city.

A forest of collapsed skyscrapers. A downtown district that must once have been the most dazzling part of the city, now reduced to desolation…

We moved as quickly and quietly as possible.

After traveling for some time with our senses stretched to their limits, Lee Jungryong, who had been leading the group, suddenly spoke.

"Did you know?"

"If you put it like that, of course I don't. And this doesn't seem like a particularly good time to play Twenty Questions."

Lee Jungryong let out a low laugh at my immediate reply.

"These days, I find myself thinking about you more than usual."

“Are you confessing your feelings to me? This is a bad time for that too.”

“In a sense, perhaps I am. How should I put it? I find myself thinking that you will surpass me someday.”

“You don’t need to worry about that. Even in ten years, I won’t come close to catching up with you, Vice Guild Master.”

“Haha. Do you really think so?”

“No. I just said it because I thought you’d like to hear it.”

“You’re as honest as ever. Just like when I first met you.”

“That first blind date did have a pretty terrible atmosphere.”

My memory was not particularly good, but I could still vividly remember my first meeting with him.

Lee Jungryong seemed to remember it just as clearly.

“We got off to an ill-fated start. The more I think about it, the more regrettable it seems.”

“Tell me about it. If we had talked things out from the start instead of cutting off someone’s arm, we might have begun on relatively friendly terms.”

“Park Jihoon made a mistake in the heat of the moment. I apologize.”

“How could that have been the Disciple’s fault alone?”

“Heh. I see. Then it was also my fault for failing to teach him properly.”

I watched Lee Jungryong’s back as he moved ahead of us. He leaped between buildings with swift, elusive movements, and I wondered what expression he was wearing now.

Lee Jungryong let out another quiet laugh and continued.

“You seem to have grown quite close to Minwoo.”

“We’re reasonably friendly.”

“You two seem to get along surprisingly well.”

“He pays me a lot.”

“A business relationship. That’s good to hear. Then do you think I could become close to you as well?”

I answered with a snort of laughter.

“Was it about seven years ago? I had a red-bean bun as a snack at the Hunter Training Center, and it tasted so good I cried. But when I tried one after getting out into the real world, it wasn’t that great. I haven’t really eaten them since.”

“So now you’ve had your fill?”

“I’ve already earned enough for several generations to live without working. My stomach is full, so what’s the point of forcing down more? I’ll just burst and die.”

“You’re wrong. Humans are always hungry creatures. No matter how much they stuff themselves, they never know satisfaction. Do you know why?”

“Hmm. Do you happen to have a binge-eating disorder?”

Lee Jungryong continued in a gentle voice.

“Greed. More money, more honor, or the opposite sex. We constantly desire and crave more.”

“Like you, Vice Guild Master?”

“That’s right. Like me.”

Lee Jungryong laughed aloud. His booming laughter spread through the thick fog, but he did not seem concerned in the slightest.

“They say laughter brings good fortune, but in this case, don’t you think it might bring monsters instead?”

“There aren’t any monsters in this area. You know that too, don’t you?”

“Well, I’m just saying we should be a little more careful.”

Whoooooosh!

A foul-smelling wind brushed across my entire body.

From one building to the next, we continued running, leaping across gaps more than twenty meters[1986] wide.

We sensed no sign of monsters, and the buildings around us gradually grew fewer.

“Let’s slow down from here.”

“It’s dark. And narrow.”

“Bear with it a little longer. More importantly, may I ask you one more thing?”

“Anything.”

“What did Minwoo say about this operation?”

“He didn’t say much…”

I looked between Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing before continuing slowly.

“He told me not to go because it was dangerous.”

“More precisely?”

“Don’t go with people you can’t trust. Something like that.”

The smile on Lee Jungryong’s lips deepened.

“Do you suspect me and that fellow too?”

No.

“Then?”

“If anything…”

I smiled as I continued.

“If anything, I’m certain.”

“Certain?”

“Yes.”

Still smiling, I went on.

[1986] Twenty meters is about 65.6 ft.

“I’m certain these fucking bastards are more interested in the back of my head than the Arch Lich.”

Lee Jungryong stopped dead.

Chapter 417

I knew. I had simply been waiting.

Waiting for the moment they sank their fangs into me.

“More than that… I’m certain.”

“Certain?”

“Yes.”

The corners of my mouth rose before I could stop them. I finally let out the words I had swallowed time and time again.

“I’m certain these fucking bastards are more interested in the back of my head than the Arch Lich. That’s what I’m certain of.”

“…!”

“…!”

The brief masquerade came to an end.

Step.

Lee Jungryong stopped walking.

Fwish!

The sound of displaced air came from behind me. Three streaks of wind tore toward vital points across my body.

I didn’t need to turn around to know where Wu Heixing’s daggers were headed.

Or what I needed to do.

Fwish-fwish-fwish!

The three daggers aimed at my nape, spine, and right arm missed their targets and pierced empty air.

No. That’s not it.

Maybe it was because I had pushed my senses to their absolute limit.

Everything moved slowly, each detail crystal clear.

I reached out and caught the hilt of the dagger skimming past my right arm. At the same time, I twisted at the waist and whipped my arm forward like lightning.

Shraaaaaaaaaash!

“Hup!”

Wu Heixing, who had been charging toward me, hurriedly swung his sword.

Boom!

Along with a muffled, thunderous roar, his body was knocked backward. A low voice stopped Wu Heixing as he prepared to charge again, his face twisted in anger.

“Enough.”

“Mr. Lee. Why…?”

“He’s not someone you can handle. Wait a moment.”

After restraining Wu Heixing, Lee Jungryong gazed at me calmly.

“You’re remarkably perceptive.”

I let out a quiet laugh at his sudden change in tone.

“An old man who knows everything is saying something obvious. If I didn’t have even this much sense, I’d have died a long time ago.”

“When did you know?”

I answered without hesitation.

“The moment we first met.”

The day I stormed into Myeongdong Guild alone, Lee Jungryong and I had already become irreconcilable enemies.

It had been decided the moment that bastard Park Jihoon sent a Black Hunter to cut off Uncle Kkeokjeong’s arms.

“If you’re about to tell me that was merely your subordinates being overzealous, roll up that white-coated tongue of yours and shove it back in your mouth.”

“Of course not. I merely find it regrettable.”

“What do you regret? Your future spent smelling funeral incense from behind a folding screen?”

Lee Jungryong shook his head.

“No. I had taken quite a liking to you.”

“Then you shouldn’t have cut off my man’s arms.”

“It was a light warning. I wanted to teach that boy Choi Minwoo a lesson. At the time, a brat named Jin Taekyung wasn’t someone I needed to take seriously.”

“And now?”

Lee Jungryong answered with a gentle smile.

“I came here myself. Is that answer enough?”

“More than enough.”

I leaned my back against a pile of collapsed concrete, holding White Flame at an angle.

Wu Heixing stood to my left and Lee Jungryong to my right. Each was a little over ten meters[1987] away, but any of us could erase that distance in the blink of an eye.

“But this is unexpected. I thought you’d at least wait until after we killed the Arch Lich before making your move.”

“Pfft! You stupid bangzi![1988]”

Wu Heixing abruptly cut in with a snicker.

Only a few days ago, he hadn’t even been able to meet my eyes. Now he declared triumphantly,

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[1987] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

[1988] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans.

“Fighting the Arch Lich is your job, Jin Taekyung.”

“What kind of bullshit… Ah.”

A thought flashed through my mind, and a hollow laugh escaped me.

I had wondered if it could really be true, but they had actually gone that far.

Their brains were wired completely differently from mine.

“Hah. These fuckers really thought of everything. This is beyond anything I imagined.”

“Do you understand now? Do you understand what kind of situation you’re in?”

“So… you never intended to fight the Arch Lich in the first place?”

Wu Heixing curled his lips and spoke.

“Why should I—why should I take that kind of risk?”

“…!”

“Today’s battle will go down as a defeat. And your name will be written at the very top of the list of the war dead. I’ve already decided on your epitaph.”

Wu Heixing spread his arms like a stage actor.

“Bangzi from Korea, killed by the Arch Lich. What do you think? Isn’t that a fine epitaph?”

Even after Wu Heixing finished speaking, I could not find anything to say for a while. I stood there blankly, like a madman, and the goose bumps covering my body refused to fade.

Was it because of his scheme?

No.

One question Wu Heixing had thrown back at me continued to circle through my empty mind.

Why should I take that kind of risk?

I felt completely blindsided.

At the same time, countless deaths I had witnessed over the past month flashed before my eyes, along with horribly mutilated bodies.

Young parents who had met their end while holding their precious child tightly, hoping against hope that their little one might survive.

An elderly person too infirm to flee, torn apart and eaten.

A pregnant woman who had died clutching her full-term belly.

And…

The day I became a Hunter, I swore that I would fight monsters until the moment my life ended. That oath still stands.

Lei Fei, who had fulfilled his mission until the very last moment.

The five hundred Public Security Armed Forces Department Hunters who defied death and launched their heroic charge.

Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen, who had prepared to die and bound their hands to their sword hilts with strips of cloth so they could kill one more monster.

You're right. Why did all of them take such risks? Like fucking idiots.

Their faces flashed before my eyes, one after another.

My insides burned as though I had swallowed a fireball, and a hot breath escaped me.

I drew a deep breath, then looked at one man.

"Tell me."

"What should I tell you?"

"Whether you think the same way as that bastard."

"I don't. Not at all. That fellow is afraid of the Arch Lich, but…"

Lee Jungryong continued gently.

"I seized an opportunity. The longer this war lasts, the more I stand to gain."

After a brief silence, I gave a small nod.

"I see."

I pushed away from the concrete. Scorching Yang Qi boiled like lava, surging through every limb and bone and hundreds of acupoints. Blue flames danced along White Flame's spearhead.

"Let me ask you one thing too."

"Anything."

"'The only good chink is a dead chink. Fucking Lee Jungryong.' Those are the epitaphs I just came up with for you two. Do you like them?"

"…!"

"…Heh."

Wu Heixing's face crumpled, while Lee Jungryong's eyes curved like crescent moons.

Then—

Fwooooooosh!

Blinding flashes burst from both sides.

Lee Jungryong had already made up his mind.

I must not let my guard down. I'll kill him by any means necessary.

A lion gives its all even when hunting a rabbit.

All the more so when its prey was a wolf named Jin Taekyung. To hunt him, the lion would have to use every ounce of its strength.

No matter how much of a lion Lee Jungryong was, he couldn't afford to ignore the wolf's fangs.

Fwish!

One step.

In a split second, Lee Jungryong closed the distance of more than ten meters[1989], and his hand blurred.

A longsword flashed from its scabbard and shot forward in a dazzling streak of light.

Straight at one man—Jin Taekyung.

Fwooooooosh!

It was a full-power strike, the likes of which Lee Jungryong had not unleashed anywhere else in this war.

Wu Heixing had joined the attack as well.

Compared to Jin Taekyung, he was a fledgling far behind in ability, but he was still an S-rank Hunter capable of wielding an Aura Blade.

“Dieeeee!”

As Wu Heixing screamed, his eyes bloodshot, Lee Jungryong saw it clearly.

Jin Taekyung’s smooth, gliding movement.

The spearhead wreathed in blue flames.

Boom!

Two swords and one spear collided.

An immense wave of qi erupted with a thunderous roar, collapsing buildings and pulverizing concrete.

Rumble! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

It looked as though the city had been bombarded.

The ground caved in, and a tremendous tremor swept across a radius of several hundred meters[1990].

But this was only the beginning.

Fwish-fwish-fwish-fwish!

Dozens, then hundreds of lines slashed through the air.

Lee Jungryong’s sword moved too quickly for the eye to follow, carving Jin Taekyung to pieces.

Or so he had believed.

Until Jin Taekyung slammed a flame-wreathed palm into Wu Heixing’s chest and sent him flying, then brought down his spear.

Fwoosh—whooooooosh!

Blistering heat blazed up, burning the air itself.

[1989] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

[1990] Several hundred meters is several hundred to over a thousand ft; 300 m is about 980 ft.

The spearhead devoured both the thick fog blanketing the city and the humidity in the air as it came down diagonally at Lee Jungryong with ferocious momentum.

It was like the claw of a dragon striking down from the heavens.

What is this…?

Lee Jungryong frowned.

Jin Taekyung's spearhead was rushing toward him, erasing the Aura he had scattered.

The tremendous heat stole his breath and made his body seize up.

The young man before him, not yet thirty, was no longer the Jin Taekyung he had known.

How did he improve this much in such a short time…?

But although Jin Taekyung's strength far exceeded his expectations, Lee Jungryong was also a superhuman who stood above other S-rank Hunters.

In that split second, he laid his blade across the spearhead's path.

Kwaaaaaaaaaang!

Jin Taekyung's spear was faster and stronger than Lee Jungryong had expected.

But the same was true of Lee Jungryong.

Swing—fwish-fwish-fwish-fwish!

Within a moment sliced into ever smaller fractions, spear and sword tangled and collided.

Lightning-like flashes and thunderous roars erupted without pause.

Clack-clack-clack!

Jin Taekyung pressed Lee Jungryong's sword down with his spearhead, then thrust out his hand.

Just before a palm strike carrying the heat of the Flame Divine Palm could slam into Lee Jungryong's chest, Lee Jungryong's fist shot forward like lightning and met Jin Taekyung's palm.

Boom!

With the sound of compressed air bursting apart, the two men stepped backward as though they had planned it.

The result left Lee Jungryong stunned.

He had retreated two steps.

Jin Taekyung had retreated only one.

He pushed me back?

Lee Jungryong had accumulated an enormous amount of qi over many years.

Yet a brat barely in his late twenties had forced him backward.

It was impossible to believe that such a change had occurred in the short span of just over a month.

And that isn’t all.

His incredible power and speed seemed to have no bottom. His movements, too—everything about him was astonishing. Beyond anything that could be put into words.

Just as he was now.

Whooooooosh! Fwish!

Lee Jungryong twisted his head aside.

The spearhead missed him by half a handspan[1991], then changed direction in midair.

Slash!

A searing sensation, followed by droplets of blood scattering through the air.

For the first time in a very long while, Lee Jungryong felt pain.

He swung his sword.

Boom!

Their weapons crashed together.

Through the transparent spearhead, Lee Jungryong saw the young man’s blazing eyes.

The lips that had remained tightly sealed throughout the battle finally parted, and a cold, level voice emerged.

“You’re fucked.”

The moment Lee Jungryong heard those chilling words, he realized he needed to revise his earlier assessment.

A lion.

He had been wrong.

Jin Taekyung was not a wolf.

He was a lion—a powerful young male who might drive out the old lion that had ruled the pride for so long and become its new king.

Craaaaaack! Boom!

The old lion was hurled away by an irresistible force.

Lee Jungryong flipped in midair and landed on the ground.

The first thing he saw was the young male lion gripping Wu Heixing by the throat after Wu had attempted a surprise attack.

“Guhk! M-my father belongs to the Crown Prince Party…!”

“I don’t care.”

“If you let me live, I’ll repay you! Guh! So please…”

“Me? Let you live after you tried to kill me?”

[1991] A handspan is the distance between the tips of an outstretched thumb and little finger. Half a handspan is roughly 10 cm (4 in), though it varies by hand.

A reddish gaze turned toward Wu Heixing.

Then a sentence Lee Jungryong had heard somewhere before slipped from Jin Taekyung's lips.

"Why should I—why should I take that kind of risk?"

"…!"

Crunch!

Chapter 418

Sometimes, when I took someone's life—when I faced the desperate voices and pleading eyes of enemies begging to be spared—I found myself wondering.

Why? Why on earth?

Why didn't they stop to think about what they themselves had done? Why did they always look to others for the cause of everything that befell them?

Too late.

If you tried to kill someone, you had to consider the possibility that you might be killed instead.

The seeds had already been sown. At last, it was time to reap the harvest.

I stared into Wu Heixing's bloodshot eyes and whispered,

"Why should I take that kind of risk?"

"…!"

I hadn't asked because I wanted an answer.

There was nothing more to hear or see. Without hesitation, I grabbed Wu Heixing by the neck and twisted.

Crunch.

Flesh was crushed and bones splintered beneath a grip strong enough to tear steel like paper.

The last light faded from his wide, frozen eyes.

The instant his struggling body went limp, a System notification rang out.

SYSTEM

Defeated Lv. 135 Wu Heixing!
Gained a substantial amount of EXP!
Gained no Fame. If it becomes known that you killed this person, significant repercussions are expected!

That was when Lee Jungryong rose to his feet more than twenty meters[1992] away and spoke.

"Not even a moment's hesitation."

I tossed Wu Heixing's lifeless body aside.

"He needed to die."

"Do you know who that boy's father is?"

"I've heard of him. Apparently, he was one of the men who took a sledgehammer

[1992] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

to Confucius's tomb decades ago."[1993]

"And that young Red Guard grew up to become the most powerful man in Chinese politics and the leader of the Crown Prince Party. Even Chairman Xiao Yang does not dare touch him."

"Damn. What a fucking amazing continent. In our country, that'd be like the arsonist who burned down Sungnyemun[1994] becoming President. Don't you think?"

"There is no need to understand it. But there is one fact you must know. With your own hands, you killed the only son that the most powerful man among one billion people had after turning fifty."

"Me? No, I didn't."

I smiled shamelessly.

"Wu Heixing died after a fierce battle with the Arch Lich."

"…!"

"I told you, I already picked out his epitaph. *Here lies a bad chink who became a good Chinese man.* Of course, your gravestone will be right beside his."

Lee Jungryong stared at me with an inscrutable expression, then let out a quiet laugh.

"You're a crafty one."

"I liked the scenario you two came up with. Let me borrow it."

"Do as you please. It will not go the way you wish regardless."

"Maybe…"

I gestured toward Wu Heixing's sprawled corpse with my chin.

"So far, things seem to have gone more or less my way."

"Yes. In that respect, you and I are alike."

"What?"

As I frowned, Lee Jungryong gave me a faint smile.

"Wu Heixing was easily swayed and loose-lipped. A terrible man to conspire with, but even someone like him had his uses."

"…What the fuck are you talking about?"

"This is what I mean."

Lee Jungryong pressed something in his hand. A beam pierced the thick fog and struck a chunk of concrete, projecting a hologram above it.

The short video, barely ten seconds long, showed Wu Heixing begging for his life—and me breaking his neck without a moment's hesitation.

"Huh."

[1993] The reference is to the Red Guards' attack on Confucius's tomb during the Cultural Revolution.

[1994] Sungnyemun, also known as Namdaemun, is Seoul's historic South Gate and a major Korean landmark.

I let out a hollow laugh.

“Nice image quality. Perfect for giving people the wrong idea.”

“Indeed. Especially an old father who has lost his only son, born late in life.”

“Are you planning to show them the unedited version?”

“Perhaps because of the magical power’s influence, an error will probably cause the beginning of the video to be lost.”

“That’s one hell of a coincidence.”

“Anyone who sees it will be appalled. Not only those who delight in tearing others down, but even those who worshipped you will turn against you. And the people you cherish so dearly will slowly crumble beneath the public’s condemnation.”

The Peace Guild.

And Mom and Hayeon.

Their names and faces flashed before my eyes the moment I heard Lee Jungryong’s words.

I stepped forward, planting my foot on Wu Heixing’s corpse.

Step.

“Was this your plan from the beginning?”

“Wu Heixing was merely a tool from the start. He could never have been anything more.”

Step.

Lee Jungryong began walking toward me as well.

But the qi pouring from his entire body was on a completely different level from anything he had shown before.

That was why Wu Heixing’s death had failed to disturb his composure.

The cunning beast had achieved its objective. Now, at last, it had bared the claws it had kept hidden.

“Damn it. No wonder it seemed so easy.”

Lee Jungryong gave a dry laugh at my complaint.

“I will praise you for one thing. You far exceeded my expectations.”

“Let me ask you one last time. Why are you going this far?”

“Could a young pup like you possibly understand?”

Step.

“Were you really that afraid of Team Leader Choi—no, Choi Minwoo?”

“Will you not shut that mouth of yours?”

Kuwaaaaaaaang!

A massive wave of qi surged outward, driving back the fog and seizing control of the space around us.

The razor-sharp killing intent made my skin prickle. Anger unlike anything I had ever seen rose in Lee Jungryong's once-placid eyes.

"I won my place entirely through my own strength. It is my empire, built over the course of my entire life!"

It was anger he had kept buried, an emotion he had not allowed himself to show in a very long time.

Lee Jungryong glared at me with fire blazing in his eyes and ground out each syllable.

"No one can bring it down. Not you, not that boy Minwoo, and… not even my hyung!"[1995]

Hyung?

I was given no time to question the unexpected word.

Step.

A single step rang out, unusually heavy and deep.

At the same time, Lee Jungryong's form rippled like water.

The beast vanished, leaving behind an afterimage, and appeared right in front of me.

Fweeeeeeeeng!

A mass of light filled my vision. I twisted at the waist and swung White Flame.

The instant light and flame collided, a thunderous roar erupted as though the sky itself had split apart.

Kwaaang!

The explosion was enormous.

The high-rise building that had barely been holding together collapsed as if it had burst apart, while glass and concrete broke into countless tiny fragments that pierced through everything in every direction.

The impact of the clash could likely be felt from dozens of kilometers[1996] away.

Amid the successive collapses and thunderous booms, I thrust out my foot.

Fwish!

Beyond the dust cloud splitting apart before me, a man stood poised in midair as though on solid ground.

His clear eyes, always impossible to read, now blazed with fury.

"Jin Taekyung!"

Neither of us waited for the other.

[1995] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[1996] One kilometer is about 0.62 mi; two dozen kilometers is about 15 mi.

I shattered the ground as I sprang upward, while he stepped on empty air and plunged toward me.

The sword and spear we swung at each other collided dead-on, and an immense shock wave engulfed us both.

Hurled backward at the same instant as though we had planned it, we kicked off the structures of the already-ruined city and shot toward each other again.

Shweeeeeek—Kwang!

With a thunderous boom, Lee Jungryong's sword deflected my spearhead and thrust straight toward my throat.

Boom!

I jerked my head aside. Air shrieked past, and severed strands of hair scattered behind me.

But it wasn't over.

Shwish-shwish-shwish!

Lee Jungryong's sword shot forward as a streak of pure white light.

A net of Force flowed along the blade.

Faced with that spectacle of light filling my vision, I awakened all the internal energy sleeping within my dantian.

Three jiazi[1997] of Scorching Yang Qi rose like a wildfire and seeped into my four limbs and hundreds of bones. Blue hellfire surged along the transparent spearhead, rippling smoothly like a dragon's tail.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Whooooooosh!

A single swing.

The fire dragon's tail fanned outward, erasing part of the onrushing net of Force.

Now it was time to tear the loosened net apart with sharpened claws.

Heavenly Strike.

The Fire Dragon Divine Spear consisted of only two forms.

And yet the former Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan who created it earned the epithet of the greatest spearman under heaven, leaving behind a brief final testament about his martial arts.

> "A martial art I devoted my entire life to, yet failed to complete. Even so, a spear art worthy of being called the greatest under heaven."

His words were true.

That was the Fire Dragon Divine Spear. A spear art that could proudly call itself the greatest under heaven with only two forms, and…

[1997] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi is 180 years.

Kuwaaaaaang!

Heavenly Strike, unleashed with all my power, tore through the net of Force and swept across everything ahead of it.

The flames were upon Lee Jungryong before he had any chance to react. Watching them rush toward him, he brought his sword down with a forceful shout.

“Ha!”

Fwish!

The flames split at the tip of his sword.

His form shot forward like an arrow through the paths of fire opening to either side, unleashing countless sword strikes.

Shu-shu-shu-shu-shuk!

Chest, throat, shoulder, arms, legs…

Within a span of time short enough to be called an instant—

Faced with arcs of swordlight slashing toward me like rays of light, I was suddenly seized by wonder.

How? How is this possible?

I was a Hunter. At the same time, I was a martial artist.

No. Perhaps *Player* was the name that suited me best.

On a sweltering summer day, I had picked up a discarded VR capsule at a recycling station and gained a new power called the System. I had become the only person to stand astride both the modern world and Murim.

But still…

Boom!

Movements without a single wasted inch, nearly perfect control of power, and even control over qi.

After parrying Lee Jungryong’s attack, I found myself admiring him. It had nothing to do with what kind of person he was. I was simply stunned by his skill.

So he was this strong.

After reaching the Supreme Peak realm, I had thought there would not be many people in the modern world capable of matching me.

After coming to Sichuan and meeting several S-rank Hunters, that belief had only grown stronger.

No matter how much energy each of them possessed, martial arts did not exist here.

The so-called Hunters could fight efficiently, but when it came to efficient qi manipulation, they were practically illiterate.

Lee Jungryong? I knew he had learned a cultivation technique called the Mana Cultivation Method in the modern world, but I had assumed it wouldn’t be much different.

Now I realized the truth.

My arrogance had led me to the wrong conclusion.

Slash!

My thigh suddenly felt cool. A heartbeat later, pain as hot as fire followed.

But why did my mind clear and my vision sharpen, as though I had just awakened from a long sleep?

Slash, slash, slash!

My arm. My calf. The back of my neck.

Blood sprayed out, and the qi carried through his Force disrupted the flow of my internal energy.

As I staggered, I looked at Lee Jungryong's face while he continued raining sword strikes down upon me.

His forehead glistened with sweat. At the same time, his eyes seemed certain of victory, and a smile hung at the corners of his mouth.

Ah. I don't like this.

I didn't like that smile. I didn't like the fact that a man like him possessed this much power.

Something surged inside me, and I swung White Flame.

Kwaang!

The first exchange.

Blood flowed from the cuts inflicted earlier, and pain spread through me. Without a word, I thrust my spear forward again.

Lee Jungryong, who had stepped back, charged into me with a calm smile.

Boom!

The second exchange.

Lee Jungryong retreated two steps and stared at me in surprise.

He still had that much strength left?

The thought was written plainly across his face.

Of course I do.

I muttered inwardly, adjusted my grip on the spear, ignored the faint pain spreading through me, and stepped forward.

Boom! Boom! Kwaang!

Three times. Four times. Five times.

Each time spear and sword collided and thunderous roars erupted, Lee Jungryong's expression hardened further.

The smile at the corners of his mouth had vanished long ago.

"You bastard…!"

Hearing that growling shout instead of his usual voice, soft as a cat’s paw, made me laugh for some reason.

Intoxicated by my own strength, I had underestimated his skill and made a foolish mistake.

But Lee Jungryong had done the same.

The claws he had bared were certainly strong and sharp, but they were not enough to kill me.

“Jungryong.”

I drew a deep breath, and stale air and a foul stench flooded my lungs.

Even so, I felt refreshed, as though something inside me had finally opened wide.

Yes. Now I understood.

“Let’s clip those claws.”

Lee Jungryong would die here today.

Chapter 419

Lee Jungryong suddenly wondered.

Where had things gone wrong? And what had gone wrong?

Driving out his hyung's[1998] bloodline and seizing control of Ares Guild?

Committing all manner of crimes to keep the Guild growing, then feeding his greed without ever learning to be satisfied?

Or perhaps…

Making an enemy of him?

Lee Jungryong's gaze settled on one person—a young man whose body was stained with blood from the bleeding wounds covering him.

The young man looked up at the sky, drew a deep breath, and parted his lips.

"Jungryong."

Why was it? The moment Lee Jungryong heard that quiet voice, a chill ran down his spine. Though he had not suffered a single wound, he felt as if a blade had cut him.

Looking at him, Jin Taekyung formed a savage grin.

"Let's clip those claws."

"…!"

Fwish!

The wind stirred, and in the instant the space between them vanished, Lee Jungryong swung his sword with a sharp whistle.

Shwick!

A dazzling concentration of qi sliced through Jin Taekyung's body. But instead of blood, only wind scattered through the air.

An afterimage. Not the real thing.

A red alarm bell rang in Lee Jungryong's mind.

Behind me!

It was too late to swing his sword. Lee Jungryong spun around like lightning and drove out his fist.

A fist wrapped in pure-white Force collided with a palm carrying blue flame.

Kwaang!

The world shook.

No—the thing shaking was Lee Jungryong's vision.

Flung backward by an irresistible force, he twisted in midair and righted himself.

[1998] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close relationship.

His fist throbbed, and something surged up from deep inside him. But he was not even given time to spit out the blood.

Shweeeeeek!

A spearhead had already rushed up to his face.

The spear Jin Taekyung had hurled was aimed straight at Lee Jungryong's chest. Gritting his teeth, he poured all his strength into knocking it upward with his sword.

Kagagagagak! Kwaang!

The spear narrowly missed and smashed through the concrete, leaving a massive crater.

Lee Jungryong succeeded in deflecting it, but the spear's terrifying power and spin tore his hand open, sending blood spraying into the air.

He paid it no mind and thrust his foot through the thick cloud of dust.

Boom!

The dust and fog scattered in every direction, unable to withstand his blinding speed.

At the end of Lee Jungryong's step stood a single person.

"Reckless, aren't you? My kind of guy."

Jin Taekyung was already holding a new spear. He brought the spearhead down in slashes from every direction. Space split apart, and flames surged upward.

The tip of Lee Jungryong's sword pierced straight through the center.

Whoom! Boom!

Compressed air burst outward. The flames parted, opening a new path.

Lee Jungryong shot through it like an arrow, charging toward Jin Taekyung.

Die.

His sword held a single thought. It shone brilliantly and moved as fast as light.

Yet within the slowed-down world, Jin Taekyung's eyes were clearly smiling.

This is…

Something was wrong.

Before Lee Jungryong could finish the thought, Jin Taekyung's hand gripping the spear blurred.

At the same time, tremendous force slammed into the blade that had seemed poised to pierce Jin Taekyung's throat.

Shick! Kwaang!

A thunderous boom rang out, loud enough to leave his ears ringing.

Lee Jungryong slid more than ten meters[1999] against his will and swallowed the blood rising in his throat.

[1999] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

It isn't over yet.

He could not fall. He could not show weakness.

He was Lee Jungryong—the man who had fought his way through the vortex of the Great Cataclysm, the most violent upheaval in human history. An ambitious warlord born of his age.

Lee Jungryong tightened his grip on his sword, now webbed with fine cracks.

I won't die. I can't die.

There had been countless twists and turns on the road that had brought him here. He had known bottomless despair and days of unbearable rage.

He had spent half his life in someone else's shadow, branded as number two.

No. Perhaps even now…

But…

"Not anymore."

Crack. Crack-crack-crack.

Veins bulged across his body, and his muscles swelled.

Powerful qi erupted from Lee Jungryong's entire body, pressing down on everything around him.

He drew out every last scrap of strength he had saved for the very end and glared at Jin Taekyung with bloodshot eyes.

"He's as good as gone now. The greatest in the world is… me."

Vrrrrrrm.

Everything around Lee Jungryong trembled.

Jin Taekyung watched him with calm eyes that held not the slightest hint of doubt.

"I don't think so."

Kuwaaaaaang!

The waves of energy pouring from both men clawed at everything around them.

In a fleeting instant split into countless fragments, they charged toward each other at the same time.

Kwaang!

Their collision came like a flash of light, and the aftermath was immense.

Amid thunderous booms that shook the world, they became two streams of wind twisting together.

A spearhead wrapped in blue flame and a sword enveloped in dazzling light flew at each other.

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish!

Masses of light tore through space as they charged.

Jin Taekyung kicked off the ground and soared into the air, driving his spear down with tremendous force.

One strike. Two. Three.

Every time spear and sword collided, a thunderous boom erupted along with a massive shock wave.

Before long, blood from the corner of Lee Jungryong's mouth was scattering in droplets.

"Cough."

He staggered for an instant.

At the brief glimpse of weakness shown by the old lion, the young male lion bared his teeth.

The spearhead swept horizontally, slashing fiercely toward Lee Jungryong's side.

Kwaang!

The ground shook as though an earthquake had struck.

They were close enough to feel each other's breath. Lee Jungryong barely managed to block the spear, and over their locked weapons, his gaze met Jin Taekyung's blazing eyes.

He's young. Just as I once was.

Why?

Why had that thought come to him now, of all times?

Why had remembering his own pathetic, wretched past kept him from blocking Jin Taekyung's flame-wreathed palm?

Boom!

Heat.

The qi protecting every inch of his body shattered, and terrible heat seeped deep into his lungs.

Amid the blue flames filling his vision and the searing pain, memories from long ago flashed through Lee Jungryong's mind like arrows.

"Your name?"

"Pardon?"

"Ah, yes. I meant you."

"What's this sudden exchange of names?"

It was the early days of the Great Cataclysm. They had met while surrounded by countless monsters, trapped in a desperate life-or-death crisis.

"Just because. You looked about my age, and it was nice to see someone my age."

"Young fellow, you've suddenly gotten awfully casual. You look much younger than me."

"Then should we be friends? I don't mind."

"…Do you really have time to say things like that in a situation like this?"

"Maybe not."

Lee Jungryong had thought the man was half-mad with fear of death.

At least, he had thought so until that madman suddenly stepped forward and swept away more than several thousand monsters.

Crack-crack-crack!

"What the hell…"

"Now! Charge!"

After the battle, the man returned and asked him the same question.

"Your name?"

"Lee Jungryong… sir."

"Cool name. How old are you? Oh, I'm five years older. That's hardly a difference. Should we just be friends?"

"No. Hyung.[2000]"

He looked absurdly young and was unbelievably strong.

At their first meeting, A-rank Hunter Lee Jungryong had found his hero—and, at the same time, an immense mountain range he could never cross.

"By the way, hyung.[2001]"

"Yeah?"

"What's your name…?"

"Oh, I haven't told you yet."

The man had grinned and said,

"Cheon Taemin."

Cheon Taemin. Cheon Taemin. Cheon Taemin…

No matter how many times he repeated the name, it resonated deeply within him.

Even when he tried to forget, the face remained etched in his mind.

A giant who cast an immense shadow over Lee Jungryong's life.

"Get lost! I said get out of my sight right now—!"

Lee Jungryong roared, his voice boiling with rage.

The vision that had been bleached white with pain shattered like glass, and the wind rushing past his ears was fierce.

When he came to his senses, he was crashing through a high-rise building and slamming into cold concrete with tremendous force.

Kwa-gwa-gwang!

"Cough."

Dark-red blood spurted between his lips.

[2000] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close relationship.

[2001] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close relationship.

His vision blurred, and pain assailed him from every part of his body.

Perhaps his shattered ribs had pressed against his organs, because breathing was difficult. His broken left arm and leg dangled uselessly.

A potion. The potion…

This was his last chance.

The attack had stopped, if only for a moment. He had to heal himself now.

Lee Jungryong groped at his side with his relatively uninjured right arm, but the spot where his dimensional pouch should have been was empty.

Instead, he found someone approaching from far away.

“Ah, looking for this?”

Rrrrrroll. Clink.

A magic-enhanced glass bottle rolled over and came to rest at Lee Jungryong’s feet.

It was a Top-Grade Potion, a miraculous medicine said to save anyone as long as they still drew breath.

There was, however, a considerable difference between it and the state Lee Jungryong remembered.

“I was so thirsty that I drank it. Man, it was refreshing. Did you just come back from a mineral spring?”

As Jin Taekyung approached, speaking as casually as ever, Lee Jungryong let out a hollow laugh.

Jin Taekyung.

His name, face, and personality were all different.

But at that moment, Lee Jungryong finally understood.

When he had first encountered Jin Taekyung, he had felt something familiar deep in his chest. He had tried to ignore it, disguising it beneath the words *anxiety* and *interest*.

“Jungryong.”

The quiet voice pierced his ears.

Jin Taekyung was already standing before him, the image of another person superimposed over his face.

Lee Jungryong groaned out the words.

“Who are you? Who the hell are you?”

He wanted to ask. He was desperate to know.

How could Jin Taekyung resemble him so closely?

Why had some lowly F-rank Hunter grown stronger instead of Lee Jungryong—the man who had followed Cheon Taemin, accomplished countless feats, and been hailed as a hero?

“Me?”

The next moment, Jin Taekyung smiled and continued,

"Jungryong's personal bully."

Then, like an echo returning from far away, the face and voice of someone buried deep in Lee Jungryong's old memories overlapped with his.

"Brothers. Sworn brothers."

The two men had spoken different words with different meanings, yet both were smiling.

Lee Jungryong stared blankly at those goddamn similar smiles, then slowly—very slowly—opened his mouth.

"I…"

Decades of his life and countless emotions rose and faded.

The wait lasted no more than an instant, yet felt like eternity. At last, a hollow voice slipped between his lips.

"I don't regret it. Never."

If someone asked whether he had not even a handful of regrets, the answer was no.

But Lee Jungryong could not regret it. He did not want to.

He simply believed this was the ending that suited him best.

"Kill me."

A cold reply fell upon Lee Jungryong's bright smile.

"Your last words. I heard them."

Fwoom.

The spearhead that followed, wreathed in blue flame unlike that cold voice.

The flames roared to life in an instant, searing with tremendous heat. Once they had burned everything away, they died down.

All that remained amid the melted concrete and blackened ruins was the trace of someone who had once been there.

And the chime of a bell that only one person in the world could hear.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Defeated Lv. 153 Lee Jungryong!
Gained a massive amount of EXP!
Level up!
Level up!

Listening to the cheerful System notification, I slowly withdrew my spear.

Damn old man.

That final smile kept coming back to me.

What kind of life had Lee Jungryong lived? What had he been thinking at the end? And then there were those movements and his strange behavior…

No. I'll think about it later.

The fight with Lee Jungryong had not been easy for me, either.

Mental exhaustion suddenly washed over me, but ironically, my body felt lighter than ever thanks to the Top-Grade Potion and the effects of leveling up.

More than anything, I had a reason to keep moving forward.

The Arch Lich.

The source of all this.

Before that bastard transformed the enormous city into a Gate, I had to kill—

"H-human."

The Skeleton Warlord's trembling voice reached me.

Every hair on my body stood on end as I raised my head.

There he was.

Chapter 420

What did people feel when they first encountered a monster?

Surprise, terror, fear, confusion?

I had no idea. It happened before I was born—or, technically speaking, back when I was still on my father's side rather than inside my mother's womb.

But those who witnessed that historic moment must have thought of the countless legends and myths handed down since ancient times.

Just as I did now.

Demon.

That was the word that flashed through my mind the instant I saw it. A massive body reaching three meters[2002] tall. Bones covered in a black sheen. A shape resembling a human's, yet fundamentally something else.

Fwoooosh.

Like the wings of a demon from myth, the robe draped over its body billowed as though it were alive.

The demon's mere presence darkened the world—or rather, the Arch Lich's red eyes cast an eerie glow.

"Human."

Just one word.

The air around me trembled. From inside my Inventory, the Skeleton Warlord muttered with a groan.

"The lord of the undead…"

His voice was steeped in fear. The law of power applied to monsters, too.

Yes. Just as the Skeleton Warlord had said, the Arch Lich was likely the lord of every undead monster in this land.

"Human. It is not too late. Even now…"

Instead of answering, I gave a small nod.

The Skeleton Warlord was right. It was not too late, and I still had more than enough opportunity left.

A chance to stop that bastard.

If this sprawling metropolis transformed into a single Gate, there would truly be no turning back.

Countless undead monsters would spread like a plague, and the Arch Lich's power would grow even stronger.

It has to be now.

[2002] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

I drew a deep breath and extended my hand. White Flame flew toward me through Seizing an Object Through Empty Space, its shaft landing in my grasp.

I stepped over the piles of collapsed concrete and trudged outside. Nothing awaited me but ruins blanketed in thick fog.

Above and below. Left and right.

No matter where I looked, there wasn't a monster in sight.

Ah, scratch that. There was one.

"Nice to meet you, you fucking bastard."

Some twenty meters[2003] overhead, the Arch Lich stood upon empty air and gazed down at me. Its red eyes gleamed.

"So it is true. You know the language of the Demon Realm. I did not mishear you."

"I studied hard. But you know me, don't you?"

"I am a being with hundreds of eyes and ears. I have been watching you all along, human."

I frowned.

"All along?"

"Yes. Your performance on the battlefield was remarkable."

A Familiar spell.

I kept the thought to myself and clicked my tongue.

"So you're a hidden-camera creep. You didn't install one in my bathroom, did you?"

"A hidden-camera creep? You speak nonsense, human."

"True. If you'd seen me through a hidden camera in my bathroom, you would've vanished from shock already. No one has ever survived looking my enormous Black Anaconda in the eye."

"Do you mean a Basilisk?"

A Basilisk was a monster from mythology whose gaze inflicted a curse of petrification.

It was also a Named Monster that had appeared exactly once during the Great Cataclysm.

"Something like that."

At least the part about being so startled that you froze was the same, right?

But the Arch Lich's response was not what I expected.

"So that is why. Why you feel strangely familiar to me."

"What?"

"Human. I sense the energy of death upon you. Dense and dark—an energy like my own."

[2003] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

"…!"

A jolt of surprise ran through me. I thought I knew what the Arch Lich meant by the energy of death.

There was someone who had been unable to hide his agitation at every word the creature spoke.

The Skeleton Warlord.

Even as a Named Monster, the Skeleton Warlord was still undead.

Had the Arch Lich caught a scent that had seeped into me after all the time I had spent with him? Or had it seen through even that other unknown space called the Inventory?

If it was the latter…

Just how far do that bastard's abilities reach?

I activated Qi Sense. A blue line shot into the sky along with a System notification.

At the same time, the Arch Lich's red eyes, flickering between its bones, curved like crescent moons.

"How interesting."

The next instant, black mana erupted from the Arch Lich's entire body and lashed against the blue line.

Beep!

SYSTEM

??? protects itself with a powerful, incomprehensible force!

Qi Sense failed! Unable to determine the designated target!

I'd suspected as much, and sure enough.

The Arch Lich looked down at my stiffened face and let out a low laugh.

"What an interesting human. Truly. Perhaps… my guess was correct after all."

"What guess? That you're about to die?"

"That will not happen. I am the lord of all undead. I am nothing like those weak and foolish humans."

The Arch Lich raised a hand made of black, glossy bone and pointed toward Wu Heixing, whose breath had stopped, and Lee Jungryong, who had been reduced to black ash.

"It was a most entertaining sight. Watching you humans kill one another brought me immense joy for the first time in a very long while. I thank you for helping me understand just how insignificant your kind truly is."

"Get lost."

“Anger makes humans stronger. Is that true of you as well?”

Fwoooosh.

The fog filling the area began to move like a living creature. As though an unseen hand were painting upon empty air, it formed a scene before me.

A city in ruins.

At the center of a horrific battlefield, where blood flowed in rivers and corpses lay piled like mountains, a man used his sword as a cane to pull himself upright.

I had seen that face only once, but I could never forget it.

The Arch Lich’s low voice echoed through the air.

“Lei Fei. That was certainly his name.”

“…!”

“He possessed a great and radiant soul. So dazzling that I coveted him merely from watching afar.”

With another small gesture, the fog shifted and painted a new scene.

Lei Fei staggering toward the Arch Lich.

Lei Fei dropping to his knees before he could reach it.

Lei Fei glaring at the sky with a face filled with rage and resentment as he breathed his last.

And then…

Lei Fei reborn as a corrupted being through the Arch Lich’s power, kneeling before his new master.

No.

The Death Knight Lord.

Fwoooosh.

A wind blew from somewhere, scattering the fog. The Arch Lich continued slowly.

“Did you know? Humans with noble souls wield even greater power once they fall. He truly was the finest material… The outcome was regrettable, but he did not turn out too badly.”

I slowly nodded.

“Keep talking.”

“I have found new material. You, human—with an even stronger and more massive soul!”

Its chilling voice thundered through the air.

Mana poured from the Arch Lich’s entire body, covering the sky like dark storm clouds and casting the city into darkness.

At the center of it all, its red eyes burned like an ominous sun.

I stood silently and watched the scene. Then I suddenly opened my mouth.

“Right, so… are you finally done running your mouth?”

My stomach was burning.

The rage I had stored up and suppressed until I met the Arch Lich reared its head.

It surged like lava from a volcanic field.

“If you’ve said everything you wanted to say…”

Something snapped inside my head.

For that moment, I forgot even the mental exhaustion from hours of fighting at the head of the suicide squad and my battles against Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing.

“Then get down here, you fucking bastard.”

If the Arch Lich’s voice was thunder, my shout was lava.

The fire dragon raced through hundreds of acupoints boiling like an active volcano. Blue flames engulfed White Flame’s transparent spearhead, radiating tremendous heat.

And then—

Shweeeeeek! Boom!

The spear of flame I launched with all my strength blew apart the dark clouds of mana and tore through the darkness.

Rumble-rumble-rumble! Fwoom!

The earth shook as dazzling blue flames painted the sky.

Several kilometers[2004] away, the humans and monsters locked in fierce battle forgot their own circumstances for a moment and stared blankly at the spectacle.

“Grrrrr…”

“What is that…?”

The light bursting from the enormous city shrouded in thick fog was warmer and more dazzling than anything else.

At least, that was how it seemed to one man standing tall and gazing at the city.

Choi Minwoo.

Mr. Jin Taekyung.

It was him. It had to be.

No one but Jin Taekyung came to mind. He was alive, and he was fighting the Arch Lich.

No. Perhaps he was fighting someone else, too.

Lee Jungryong. Wu Heixing.

Others might dismiss his concern as premature and his suspicions as baseless accusations, but Choi Minwoo knew how evil a person could become.

At least, that was what the Lee Jungryong he had known had been like.

[2004] Several kilometers is roughly 2–3 mi.

And at the same time…

He knew Jin Taekyung well, too.

You're strong. Stronger than anyone I know.

Choi Minwoo had said those words to Jin Taekyung once.

Some people might have laughed at him, but Choi Minwoo had meant them.

He believed no S-rank Hunter—not even Cheon Taemin, his maternal grandfather and the man who had defeated the Demon King Asmodeus—could be stronger than Jin Taekyung.

It wasn't a matter of skill, much less a question of whose aura was greater or stronger.

It was something only those who had come to know Jin Taekyung possessed.

Faith.

Jin Taekyung had given Choi Minwoo faith.

Cheon Taemin, the hero who had saved humanity, had pushed his young grandson out of his thoughts after the boy lost his parents.

Jin Taekyung had not.

He had rejected every temptation around him that whispered of wealth and honor, remained with the Peace Guild, and protected his people through every danger.

No matter who stood against him.

"Our opponent is the Ares Guild. It'll be a dangerous road."

"Thorny roads are kind of my specialty."

"More dangerous than anything we've faced so far."

"Team Leader."

"Yes?"

"Sometimes it's okay to be honest."

"…!"

It was the first time anyone had ever said that to him.

Butler Kim, who had been by his side since childhood, was thoughtful and warm, but he had never given Choi Minwoo that same certainty.

Jin Taekyung had, and that gave Choi Minwoo the courage to speak.

"Will you… continue staying with the Peace Guild?"

"Yeah. That's more like it."

Choi Minwoo could never forget Jin Taekyung's crooked grin.

That was the day he gained people he could call *us*, rather than Guild members bound together by a few sheets of paper called a contract.

So this is what it feels like.

He had always been alone.

Isolated and lonely.

For as long as he could remember, he had been cut off from everything around him.

The children he met in his youth were wary of him, and the adults whispered among themselves.

It hurt, but he never let it show. Only the aging Butler Kim had ever been someone he could truly confide in.

But not anymore.

A smile appeared on Choi Minwoo's lips.

Far in the distance, he watched the flames rising through the thick fog and darkness, then gripped his sword once more.

Shhk!

A monster's body split apart beneath a flash of dazzling aura.

As the brief silence and stillness that had settled over the battlefield shattered, a tremendous cry burst from Choi Minwoo's lips.

"Attack—!"

He raised his sword and charged toward the monsters, looking much like someone Lee Jungryong had seen several decades ago.

Chapter 421

There was an old saying passed down among Hunters.

Mages came in two kinds: Grand Mages, and everyone else.

Magic Johnson had proven that saying true firsthand.

Among the seven billion people on Earth, there were only three Grand Mages.

And of those three, he was the strongest War Mage. During the Great Cataclysm, he had slain countless monsters and led innumerable battles to victory.

Yet even Magic Johnson, for all his incredible achievements, had encountered a being before whom he was forced to swallow his pride.

I hate to say this, but the Arch Lich's magic is a cut above mine. Be careful, Jin.

That was how powerful the Arch Lich was. There could be no hesitation or carelessness—not even for an instant—when facing him.

—Human, hurry!

I know, damn it.

I let the Skeleton Warlord's shriek go in one ear and out the other as I poured internal energy into both legs.

Crack-crack-crack!

The solid concrete floor sank beneath me, unable to withstand the pressure transmitted into it. I bent my knees slightly, then kicked off with all my strength.

Boom!

With a thunderous roar like an exploding bomb, I shot into the air like a streak of light.

A fierce wind tore across my body, and the Arch Lich rapidly drew closer, his black robe spread like wings.

—You…

I could see them.

His trembling red eyes.

White Flame, launched with all my strength, had shattered the invisible barrier surrounding the Arch Lich and was now falling with everything it had.

Come.

I stretched out my hand. Seizing an Object Through Empty Space caught White Flame's shaft from several meters[2005] away and pulled it into my grasp.

Now!

[2005] One meter is about 3.3 ft.

[2006] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi correspond to 180 years.

I thrust the spear with all my strength. Three jiazi[2006] of Scorching Yang Qi surged up from my dantian and raced forward without restraint. Force like blue hellfire erupted over the transparent spearhead.

Fwooooooom!

And just as I became certain I had succeeded—

—Gravity.

Fwoosh!

“Hngh!”

With that sinister voice, something invisible pressed down on my entire body.

No.

It struck me.

I swallowed a breath and reached out as far as I could, but before the spearhead brimming with Force could touch the Arch Lich’s foot, my body was already falling toward the ground.

The Arch Lich, who had seemed close enough to touch, receded in an instant.

“You fucking—”

Booooom!

I crashed down like a meteor. Above my head, laughter like scraping metal rang out.

—Not bad. Amusing in its own way.

Damn skeleton bastard.

I spat out a wad of phlegm and looked up at the Arch Lich looming over me like a god.

“Good to hear. It’s only going to get more entertaining from here.”

—Humans are always dreaming futile dreams. I have seen it countless times. Driven by anger and longing, you challenge what cannot be surpassed, only to confront reality at last and fall into despair.

“That sounds a lot like the bullshit spewed by all the guys who’ve died by my hand… Do you people share a *Hundred Questions and Answers for Dealing with Jin Taekyung* or something? Hold study sessions every now and then?”

—Even so, those who died by your hand were still insignificant humans. But I am different.

“Of course you’re different, you son of a bitch. You’re already dead.”

—…!

The Arch Lich fell silent for a moment, so I continued.

“Looking at you now, someone must’ve killed you, too. Was it a human? Is that why you’ve been flaunting your inferiority complex this whole time?”

—You…

“Yep. This bastard was killed by a human.”

—Will you shut your mouth!

At his thunderous shout, the magic surrounding the Arch Lich surged violently. His red eyes, far brighter than before, glared down at me.

—I am a servant of a great king. I am not a being who can be compared to insignificant creatures like you!

I was about to fire back when the unexpected word stopped me.

Wait. A king?

Did I hear that wrong?

As the question flashed through my mind, the Skeleton Warlord answered in a trembling voice.

—This commander heard it clearly, too, wretched human. Th-then, could it be…

No way. It can't be.

I swallowed dryly and asked,

"Is the great king you just mentioned the Demon King Asmodeus?"

—Do not speak the name of His Highness.

So much for *no way*.

It really was the Demon King Asmodeus.

The Skeleton Warlord sucked in a breath despite not needing to breathe, while I muttered in disbelief,

"Huh. Asmodeus? Seriously?"

—The name of His Highness…

"But I was sure Asmodeus had been destroyed."

—The name of His Highness…

"Is Asmodeus still alive? As an Arch Demon King or something?"

—His Highness…

"Yeah, yeah, I get it—he's fucking adorable. Now answer me. Asmodeus died back then, didn't he? Or did he come back to life? If he was resurrected as an undead like you, where is he, and what's he doing now?"

At that moment, the Skeleton Warlord murmured fearfully,

—At this hour, he might be asleep…

What the fuck are you talking about? You don't sleep, either.

—I do not, but His Highness might be different.

What is the Demon King, some good little schoolboy? Do you think he turns off the television, brushes his teeth, and goes to bed when the sun goes down? And why are you using such an honorific?

—Ah! I did not even realize… But from this commander's perspective, is that not only natural?

That's true.

—Indeed. Because I am a monster.

Then don't use it.

—Why not…?

The Demon King is far away, and my fist is close.

—Ah.

The Skeleton Warlord let out an exclamation of enlightenment, then added,

—But, human. It seems the Arch Lich's magic will be getting closer in a moment.

Damn it. He's right.

I hurriedly threw myself aside. A green mist grazed me by a hair and engulfed the spot where I had been standing moments earlier.

Sssssssss!

Stone, steel, even concrete—everything within a radius of dozens of meters[2007] melted away, leaving a gaping hole.

The Arch Lich had fired a poison cloud of terrifying power. His eyes were not merely clear—they burned like torches.

—I intended to take you under my command.

"Uh, what brought that on all of a sudden?"

—I would have subdued your body and soul and used you as the vanguard of my glorious undead army.

"How much does it pay?"

—But I have changed my mind.

"No, I asked how much it pays. Don't tell me you people pay in passion,[2008] too?"

—Your flesh will be torn to pieces, and your soul will wander the River of Death for all eternity.

"Are you acquainted with the deacon at the church I went to as a kid? He said something similar to me. Said a devil like me would go to hell. If my mom hadn't stopped me, he would've become the first martyr in that church's history."

—You insignificant human. Pay the price for insulting His Highness and defiling his name.

"For once, we agree on something. Paying the price. I like that."

I nodded and lowered White Flame at an angle.

"So I'm planning to make you pay the price, too… What do you think?"

The Arch Lich opened his mouth.

The four-syllable incantation, uttered in a voice deeper and more sinister than ever, was not an answer to my question.

It was a curse that called forth death.

[2007] One meter is about 3.3 ft.

[2008] "Passion pay" is a Korean expression for low or unpaid work justified by the worker's enthusiasm.

—Dark Hand.

Whoooom!

A pair of black hands burst through the thick fog. They hurtled in from both sides as if coming together in prayer.

I leaped to avoid the Dark Hands—and another spell was waiting for me.

—Curse.

I twisted to evade the black fog descending like a net, but this time, I was too late.

No.

Perhaps the Arch Lich had anticipated my movement.

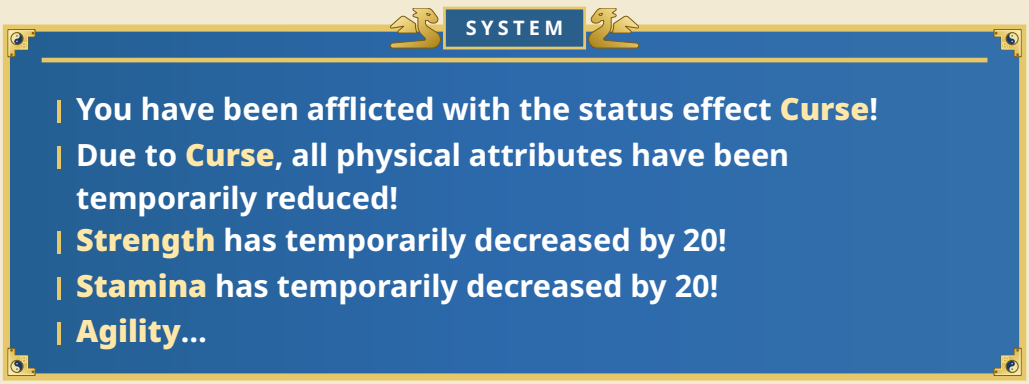
The fog had already been closing in before I even finished dodging the Dark Hands.

Shhk.

Only a paper-thin margin.

At the instant the sticky fog grazed the tip of my little finger—

Beep!



The System notification had barely sounded when my body grew heavier. I clicked my tongue inwardly.

Damn it.

I was already short on points, and now a curse had slapped me with a debuff.

This wasn't a loss of one or two points, either. With twenty points stripped from each attribute at once, I could clearly feel the difference.

But even with a debuff, I was not so helpless that I could do nothing but take his attacks.

Just like now.

—Dark Vine.

Crack! Whoooosh!

Hundreds of thorny vines burst through the ground, filling the air in every direction as they shot toward me.

I exhaled sharply and swung my spear.

Shhk!

A line of blue flame cut through the air, severing every vine formed from magic.

—Dark Vine. Dark Vine. Dark Vine.

Shwooooooosh!

From the severed ends of the thorny vines, which had been collapsing after losing their strength, new vines began to grow.

They budded, grew thorns, and swelled even larger in barely a second.

But to me, one second was as good as a minute.

Fwoom! Shhk!

A thorny vine several meters[2009] around was severed in a single blow.

Cut off from its magical connection, the dark plant toppled onto a half-collapsed high-rise building.

Amid the cloud of dust rising from the thunderous impact, I sensed an ominous fluctuation of energy.

Magic.

My prediction was right.

Shhh-shhh-shhh-shhh!

A spear stained a dull black.

A Bone Spear made entirely of bone became a streak of light and shot toward me.

No.

That wasn't it.

There isn't just one.

—Be careful, human!

Along with the Skeleton Warlord's desperate shout—

Boom!

The dust cloud exploded outward with a blast of compressed air.

More Bone Spears than I could possibly count surged toward me.

Some flew in straight lines. Some fell like meteors. Others curved through the air.

"Huh…"

—Ah.

The Skeleton Warlord and I groaned at the same time.

How many are there? Hundreds? No, thousands?

The overwhelming sight left me speechless for a moment.

A chill ran down my spine, and my mouth fell open on its own. A bead of cold sweat that had formed on my forehead slid down the bridge of my nose.

And then…

Everything stopped.

This is…

[2009] One meter is about 3.3 ft.

It was that same phenomenon that had sometimes come to me in moments of crisis.

My five senses sharpened to a razor's edge, and the world slowed down. Into the space between those moments crept something unfamiliar.

A new sense.

A sixth sense that science could not explain.

I knew its name.

The sixth sense.

At the same time, something inside me shed its shell.

My gaze traveled more and more slowly across the enormous net formed by hundreds—thousands—of Bone Spears.

Because I had already given up everything?

No.

What mattered was the essence.

Appearances could be layered over it, but the essence itself did not change.

And at that very moment, I could see it.

My parched lips parted, and an exclamation slipped out.

"Ah."

So that was it. That's what it was.

It was something I had yet to understand, even after reaching the Supreme Peak.

A flash of enlightenment streaked through my mind like lightning, and the slowed world resumed its proper speed.

Before the rain of spears pouring in from every direction, I raised my spear almost in a daze.

Then I brought White Flame down along the path I could see.

Heavenly Strike.

Fwooooooom!

The erupting flames swallowed everything.

The Bone Spears, too numerous to count, vanished.

No.

The things that vanished the instant the flames touched them were illusions made of magic.

Only the essence collided with my strike, and unable to withstand its power, it burned away.

Shhhhhhh.

Ash scattered in the wind that blew from somewhere.

Carried on that breeze, I heard a bright, cheerful ringing.

Ding. Ding. Ding…

It was such a pleasant sound that I found myself smiling without realizing it.

Chapter 422

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

In crisis lies opportunity. You have gained new insight during a battle in which life and death hung in the balance!
Your Middle Dantian has opened!
The opening of your Middle Dantian has increased all attributes by 20!
Circulating your qi has become vastly more effective!
Your ability to perceive and control the flow of qi has greatly improved!
Muscles and Bones and Sinews and Meridians have increased!

The System notifications kept ringing in my ears without pause.

A breeze stirred my sweat-soaked hair, and I felt the new power and changes permeating my entire body.

Even the final, crystal-clear chime.

Ding.

SYSTEM

As a reward for your enlightenment, you have gained a large amount of EXP!
As a reward for your enlightenment, you have gained 50 points!
Level Up!
As an effect of leveling up, all status ailments and fatigue have been cleared, and some injuries have healed!
The status effect Curse has been removed!
Your temporarily reduced attributes have returned to normal!

And I wasn't the only one who sensed the changes.

A master could hardly fail to notice what his own hand had done. Realizing that his curse magic had been broken, the Arch Lich asked in disbelief,

"How in the world?"

I shrugged at the single word that contained every question he had.

"Well."

"'Well'?"

"Yeah. Well."

"Do you think that explains anything?"

"Of course not. But why should I explain it to you?"

The faint tremor in the Arch Lich's glowing eyes conveyed his sheer incredulity.

"You are clearly not a mage."

"I wanted to be one. Mages get paid more. But I didn't have the talent. I wasn't smart enough, either."

"Even the humans you call Grand Mages could not break my magic so easily."

"They can't. But it's done."

"What utter nonsense!"

I had to admit it.

The Arch Lich's magic—no, his skill—was unquestionably superior to mine.

Even I, who had already far surpassed the limits of an ordinary Hunter, had been unable to avoid his curse magic. And his massive illusion spell using Bone Spears had been genuinely dangerous.

If I hadn't gained that insight, I might not even be standing here now.

But…

"So what are you going to do about it?"

"…!"

I had the System, and I had merely done my best with the power and effort I had been given to overcome the crisis.

If he thought that was unfair, he could use the System, too.

"That's just how the world works. Even if it feels like shit and pisses you off, you have to suck it up and move on. What else can you do? It's already happened. Right?"

The Skeleton Warlord, who had been screaming only moments ago, muttered,

"Wow. You really have a way with words."

I could be like that sometimes.

"But, devious human, that one does not appear willing to suck it up and move on."

The Skeleton Warlord was right.

The next moment, an enormous vortex of magical power formed, and an eerie voice rang out.

"Explode. Sonic Buster."

And at the same time—

Fwooooooosh! Boom!

Highly compressed wind exploded outward all at once.

The sphere of wind shot forward at the speed of sound, pulverizing concrete and snapping steel rebar with the slightest touch.

Every window in the high-rise buildings shattered under the aftershock, and countless shards of glass were swept into the gale.

In a single instant—before I could even blink—the enormous mass of wind had reached the tip of my nose.

"Human!"

The Skeleton Warlord's scream from inside my Inventory echoed like a cry from far away.

Was that bastard worried about his own safety, or mine?

Whatever the real reason, it didn't matter.

There was a world of difference between who I'd been a few minutes ago and who I was now.

Ah.

The area around my chest grew hot.

The place martial artists called the Tanzhong acupoint, or the Middle Dantian, had opened wide.

It allowed me to take in everything around me—to feel it against my skin and see it with my own eyes.

So that's what it was.

The world slowed, and everything became clear enough to see and understand.

The enormous sphere of wind, its currents whipping like blades.

And the flow of magical power that made it possible.

Shh-shh-shh-shh-shhk!

Everything had a center. Magic was no exception.

And now, I could see it.

Now.

I swung my spear through the slowed world.

The sphere of wind that looked ready to sweep away everything in its path split in two along White Flame's spearhead.

The single enormous mass broke into hundreds—thousands—of wind blades. Freed from the magical power controlling them, they veered left and right, tearing through everything around them.

Shhk! Kwa-gwa-gwa-gwa!

The raging wind whipped my clothes and hair around. With a faint smile on my lips, I looked up at the Arch Lich.

"Come down. My neck hurts."

"You…!"

"Or I can come to you."

Crack-crackle! Boom!

One stomp.

The solid ground caved in, and I shot toward the ash-gray sky.

Boom!

The instant Jin Taekyung launched himself from the ground, the Arch Lich realized what he had to do.

I must not let that human come any closer.

Every mage knew to avoid close combat, but for the Arch Lich, those words carried a different weight.

This body feels threatened by a mere human.

He prided himself on having reached the pinnacle of dark magic.

Although he had lost considerable power during his resurrection as an Arch Lich, even now he possessed enough magical power to regard Grand Mages as beneath him.

But the human hurtling toward him now…

He is dangerous.

Yes. Just like that bastard back then.

It was a memory the Arch Lich never wanted to recall again. Clenching his still-intact teeth, he cast a spell.

“Gravity!”

Unlike before, the shout carried palpable power. Invisible gravity bore down over a radius of several dozen meters.[2010]

Just as the pressure—too great for even an S-rank Hunter to resist—was about to engulf Jin Taekyung’s entire body—

Pop!

Compressed air burst from the tip of Jin Taekyung’s foot.

His body escaped the range of the gravity magic with *Stepping on Empty Air*, then stepped on the empty air again.

His graceful movements resembled a hawk’s, but no mere bird could compare to his speed.

What is this?

The red glow in the Arch Lich’s eyes darkened as he watched Jin Taekyung race through the air toward him.

Jin Taekyung had not only identified the precise range of his gravity magic but had also evaded it with some strange technique.

[2010] Several dozen meters is roughly 30–90 m, or about 98–295 ft.

As I thought. He did not dispel the illusion magic through mere luck. Then…

Whooooooooom!

Magical power poured from the Arch Lich's entire body, shaking the surrounding space.

"Gravity. Gravity. Gravity."

High-level spells that even a skilled high-ranking mage would have needed to chant at length came pouring out without pause.

This time, the Arch Lich was certain he could knock Jin Taekyung from the sky.

Fall, human.

This time, he reduced the strength of his gravity magic in exchange for expanding its range.

How could Jin Taekyung possibly escape gravity pressing down over a radius of several hundred meters[2011]—

Shhk!

The Arch Lich's glowing eyes trembled.

The gravity magic bearing down on Jin Taekyung dispersed, and the Arch Lich felt the magical power connecting him to the spell snap like a thread.

He froze for an instant, stunned that his magic had been broken.

Then Jin Taekyung stepped on empty air once more and shot toward him like a cannonball.

Bang! Shweeeeeek!

With a sharp crack through the air, Jin Taekyung hurtled in front of the Arch Lich —no, a step above him—and brought White Flame down.

Fwoom!

A line of blue flame streaked toward the Arch Lich.

Crash!

In the slowed world, the invisible barrier surrounding the Arch Lich shattered.

The flames of Force, fueled by three jiazi[2012] of Scorching Yang Qi, smashed through dozens of layered defensive spells and surged toward the Arch Lich's body.

At that very moment—

"Great Bone Wall!"

With an eerie cry, a wall of black bones rose into the air.

The highest-level defensive spell, manifested barely a meter away,[2013] collided with the flame-wreathed spearhead.

[2011] Several hundred meters is roughly 300–900 m, or about 980–2,950 ft.

[2012] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi equal 180 years.

[2013] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

High in the ash-gray sky, an enormous shock wave and a thunderous roar erupted around the two figures facing each other across the bone wall.

Kwaaang!

Compressed wind exploded outward.

The clouds circling far above scattered. Buildings that had barely maintained their shape collapsed, and half-rotted corpses were swept away by the wind.

Yet the two beings responsible for it all remained perfectly still, staring at each other through the barrier.

“That was close, wasn’t it?”

“Yes, quite impressive. No…”

The Arch Lich stared at the transparent spearhead piercing the center of the wall and continued,

“I shall call it dangerous.”

The length of the spearhead that had passed through the bone barrier was no more than the width of a finger joint, but the Force that erupted in that instant had reached the tip of the Arch Lich’s nose.

It had been a fortunate escape for the Arch Lich.

For Jin Taekyung, it had been unfortunate.

“You got lucky.”

“You are arrogant, human. But I will admit this much.”

“What?”

The Arch Lich slowly continued as Jin Taekyung stared at him in confusion.

“You have earned the right to be. If you truly are the Adversary.”

“…The Adversary?”

“That is right. The king’s Adversary. His eternal nemesis, bound to him by a god’s machinations. I cannot yet be certain, but… that must also be why I was able to rise again after stepping into the River of Death.”

Jin Taekyung frowned.

What was the king’s Adversary? And what kind of nonsense was this about a god’s machinations?

“Do you have middle-school syndrome[2014] or something? Get rid of those bones and show me your right hand. Let’s see if there’s a Black Flame Dragon in there.”

The Arch Lich shook his head.

“This is something neither you nor I can understand. But one thing is certain.”

The deeply sunken red eye-lights flared fiercely.

At first, he had thought Jin Taekyung was merely a strong and unusual human.

Not anymore.

[2014] “Middle-school syndrome” refers to adolescent fantasies of possessing hidden powers. A Black Flame Dragon is a stock example of such an imagined power.

He remembered sweeping across this planet decades ago while serving the king.

He also recalled the figure of the human he had encountered on the day he lost everything and fell into the River of Death—the first and last time he had ever met that human.

The Adversary.

The human who had killed him and even assassinated the king.

The one he had tried to stop but could not, the one he had tried to approach but could never reach—the only human he had ever feared.

And today, during his battle with Jin Taekyung, the Arch Lich had remembered that day.

“You… will definitely die here.”

His voice was eerie but more resolute than ever.

Jin Taekyung’s answer was simple.

“What the hell are you talking about, dumbass?”

And the next moment—

“Eat this, fucker.”

Fwoom! Kwaaaaaa!

With those quiet words, a fist wreathed in blue hellfire shot forward, erasing everything in its path.

It struck the curtain of black bones.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Crack-crack-crack!

The bone barrier that had seemed capable of blocking any attack collapsed.

Beyond the countless fragments of bone scattering in every direction, the Arch Lich’s face came into view.

Jin Taekyung spoke with an expressionless face.

“See how much better this is? My neck doesn’t hurt, either.”

“…!”

“Down you go.”

Wham!

A single punch, fired like a ray of light, slammed into the Arch Lich’s jaw.

Chapter 423

Wham!

The instant the heavy blow sent the Arch Lich hurtling toward the ground, I drew up my internal energy and kicked off the air.

Bang!

Compressed air exploded beneath my feet, launching me at terrifying speed toward his plummeting figure.

The Skeleton Warlord let out a cry that might have been a scream or a cheer.

“You did it, human! Hurry and finish it!”

Finish what?

Unfortunately, he was wrong. Having driven my fist directly into the Arch Lich’s jaw, I knew that better than anyone.

He cast a defensive spell in that split second…!

Before my all-out Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist could connect, he had covered his face with a Bone Shield.

Considering the force behind the blow, he could not have escaped completely unharmed, but this was not enough to bring him down.

And sure enough, the Arch Lich abruptly stopped in midair after plummeting like a meteor. Immense mana rippled through the atmosphere.

“Darkness Hold.”

Fwooooooosh!

A pair of enormous hands burst out of thin air. At a glance, they looked similar to Dark Hand, but as its name implied, Darkness Hold was a spell designed solely to bind its target.

I brought my spear down toward the two hands hurtling at me.

I can see it.

Everything had a grain. Living creatures had one. So did the wind, and even invisible energy.

Opening my Middle Dantian had allowed me to sense and see the core and grain of things.

Just like now.

Shhk!

Flames blossomed, and the darkness split apart. The black hands writhed as if in pain before dissolving into mist, and the Arch Lich’s eye-lights flashed.

The next instant, his hand of dark, weathered bone clawed through the air.

“Dark Claw!”

Fssssh! Shhk!

The dispersing black mist transformed into a beast's claws and rained down.

Countless attacks hurtled in from every direction, each tracing a different path. I could have blocked them easily enough if I committed to it.

But then I would lose the Arch Lich after finally closing the distance.

I have to choose.

I could not catch two rabbits at once—especially when the other side was not a rabbit, but a tiger.

I made my decision in that brief instant and hurled White Flame with all my strength.

Not at the magic surrounding me, but at the Arch Lich.

Fwooooooom!

Wreathed in blue hellfire, White Flame cleaved through everything in its path like a streak of light.

The Arch Lich cried out with more urgency than ever before.

"Bone Shi—"

Too late, you son of a bitch.

Fwooooooosh!

Blue hellfire swallowed the Arch Lich whole.

His half-formed bone shield turned to ash and crumbled before the blistering heat.

Crunch!

White Flame's spearhead punched through the Arch Lich's chest. Impaled like meat on a skewer, he plunged toward the ground with a shriek unlike any sound I had ever heard from him.

At that moment, I felt a chilling wind slicing in from every direction.

"Human, danger…!"

I already knew. I did not need the Skeleton Warlord's warning.

I had known and done it anyway. To take the bones, I had to give up my flesh. Even knowing I would not emerge unscathed, I had believed this was the right decision.

As I watched the claws of mana rain down from every direction, a thought crossed my mind.

…Maybe I should've just blocked them.

But there were no take-backs now.

Shh-shh-shh-shh-shhk!

A violent gust swept over my entire body.

It was not an illusion like Bone Spear, nor was it slow enough to block. I twisted my body as much as possible and gathered my internal energy, but there was a definite limit.

Shhk! Shhk! Shhk! Shraaaak!

Shoulder, side, thigh, arm…

Countless claws of mana slashed and raked across my entire body. Blood burst from the deep gashes in my skin, and overwhelming pain crashed over me.

Damn it.

It hurt. Enough to kill me.

Enough to make me want to die.

No matter how many times I experienced it, pain was something that was difficult to grow accustomed to.

My vision blurred, and the strength drained from my body before I realized it.

The agony lasted only a moment, yet seemed to stretch on forever.

When I finally opened my eyes, the first thing I saw was an enormous pile of concrete looming right in front of me.

“Get a hold of yourself, human!”

“…!”

The Skeleton Warlord’s frantic shout snapped me back to my senses.

I forced internal energy into my stiffened body. Along with the tearing pain in my acupoints, the senses that had fallen asleep awakened.

Now!

Without a moment’s hesitation, I flipped over in midair.

Crash!

A thunderous roar rose with a cloud of dust. Violent vibrations and pain slowly crawled up the leg with which I landed roughly on the concrete pile.

“Urgh.”

As I clenched my teeth against the pain, the Skeleton Warlord spoke.

“Human, you do not… appear to be all right.”

I answered between ragged breaths.

“Huff. If you know that, huff, then shut up. My head’s ringing.”

I was not exaggerating. It really was.

The System notifications drilling into my ears were enough to make me want to throw up.

Beep.

SYSTEM

The status effect Severe Injury has been applied!
The status effect Excessive Bleeding has been applied!
Due to severe injuries, your physical attributes have been drastically reduced!
Strength, Agility, and Stamina have each decreased by 200 points!
You have suffered severe injuries! Immediate treatment is required!

Yeah. I thought so, too.

Whether from losing too much blood or the relentless agony coursing through me, my vision was hazy and my thoughts barely worked.

But even in that state, there was one presence I could not forget.

“The Arch Lich. Where’s the Arch Lich?”

At the sound of my cracked voice, the Skeleton Warlord roared.

“Have you gone completely insane, human?! Treat yourself first!”

“I haven’t gotten a kill notification yet. That means he’s still ali—”

“Who cares about your kill notification?! Treat yourself first!”

“Hngh.”

I told you not to shout.

Dizzy, I leaned against the pile of concrete. Blood dripped from my body, leaving me soaked from head to toe, while my arms and legs trembled like aspen leaves beyond my control.

Damn it.

I had really taken a beating.

My one consolation was that the Arch Lich had to be in even worse shape than I was—or at least no better.

“You stupid human!”

I know. I know.

With his shout reverberating through my head, I slowly opened my palm and muttered inwardly.

Inventory open. Summon.

Pop!

The thought became reality at once.

I drew out an item from the subspace pocket that had once belonged to Lee Jungryong and now belonged to me.

A Top-Grade Potion.

Had Lee Jungryong ever imagined that both Top-Grade Potions he had brought along just in case would end up being used on me?

My hand trembling, I uncorked the potion and raised it to my lips, ready to gulp it down like the elixir of life.

Or rather, I was just about to.

Tap! Fwooooooosh!

"…Huh?"

It happened in an instant.

A black thorny vine sprang from between the slabs of concrete and struck my wrist. In the slowed world, the Top-Grade Potion flew from my hand and vanished beyond the pale haze.

I stared blankly at the few drops of potion scattered through the air as they soaked into the ground. Then I suddenly spoke.

"Dark Vine."

Someone's all-too-familiar magic.

The Skeleton Warlord muttered like he was groaning.

"It is him."

I slowly raised my head. Beyond the dense fog, a pair of red eye-lights blazed like torches as they drew closer.

A three-meter[2015] body with a black sheen emerged through the mist with heavy steps. He resembled a human, but no one could have called him one.

"You, human."

His low voice seethed with unmistakable fury.

Deep within my Inventory, the Skeleton Warlord trembled. I smiled faintly.

"You son of a bitch. You stole the food right out of my mouth."

"Your futile struggle ends here."

Shhk! Snap!

I did not even have time to reach out. The Arch Lich snapped his fingers, and Dark Vine swept up Lee Jungryong's subspace pocket—an ordinary-looking leather pouch—and flung it far out of sight.

"No more cheap tricks will work."

The mana surrounding the Arch Lich reacted to every word he spoke.

But just as I had suffered a severe injury, the power he emitted was also weaker than before.

The White Flame piercing the center of his chest had to be the decisive cause.

I can do this.

[2015] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

I forced myself upright. As I reached out, a spear summoned from my Inventory landed in my hand.

“That spear in your chest looks good on you. Want me to plant another one?”

“Will you have the chance?”

“Of course. Looking at the state you’re in, I’d say my chances are pretty good.”

“Humans never know the difference between courage and recklessness. How foolish. Truly, how foolish.”

The Arch Lich laughed aloud and spread his arms.

His robe had been reduced to ash by my earlier attack. In its place, pitch-black mana poured from his entire body and took shape.

That’s…

A vortex of mana that felt ominous just to look at.

I instinctively realized what the Arch Lich was trying to do.

A Gate.

It was unstable, as if it might explode at any moment, but it had unmistakably taken the shape of a Gate.

The Arch Lich’s next words confirmed my suspicions.

“It is not yet complete, but… if I can merely bring you down, I should be able to complete everything.”

At the same time, a low voice that seemed to come from the heavens reverberated through the space.

“Descend upon this place. Gate Open.”

“…!”

I had to stop it somehow. But pain slowed my body, and the change had already begun.

I stared wide-eyed at the sight that unfolded the next moment.

Kwaaaaaaaaaaang!

The few faint rays of sunlight piercing the ash-gray sky vanished completely.

The sky split with a thunderous roar, and a storm swept in every direction. In the void left behind, a mass of darkness rose like an ancient giant climbing to its feet.

Fwooooooosh!

The churning darkness surged from the heart of the ruined city.

As tall as a high-rise and wider than a soccer field, it dwarfed every Gate I had ever seen. The mere sight of it filled me with fear that seeped into my bones.

“Ah… ahh.”

Even the Skeleton Warlord, an undead monster, trembled before it.

I stood there with my mouth hanging open, staring blankly at the Gate. Then I suddenly realized something I had forgotten.

I have to stop it. No matter what.

The Gate might still be incomplete, but if this continued, an uncontrollable disaster would begin.

Millions—perhaps tens of millions—could die.

And among them…

Some might be my people.

Team Leader Choi, out on the battlefield. Xiao Shen, whom I had grown attached to despite our short time together.

If the Arch Lich moved beyond China and reached the Korean Peninsula… the members of the Peace Guild and even my beloved family would be in danger.

I have to go.

Will drove my body, paralyzed by pain and shock, back into motion.

I dredged up every last ounce of internal energy. My acupoints, already ravaged by internal injuries, screamed in pain, and blood burst anew from wounds all over my body.

But I did not stop.

I needed only one chance.

Just one.

Flamefire Path.

My battered leg pushed against the ground. A path of flame opened amid shattering pain.

At its end stood a single being.

The one who had started all of this.

The one who could end it all.

Die.

One Annihilation.

In the slowed world, I drew my spear back as far as I could and thrust.

The vortex unleashed with all my strength reached the Arch Lich.

Kwaaaaaaaaaaang!

And amid the blue flames filling the world, one laughter-laced word pierced my ears.

“Blink.”

Chapter 424

Kwaaaaaaaaaa!

The vortex wreathed in blue flame devoured everything in its path.

Ruined buildings with shattered concrete and bare steel frames. Human and monster corpses strewn together throughout the wreckage.

The ultrahigh heat burned and melted countless things.

All but one.

“Blink.”

All but him.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Skill One Annihilation has been used!
All internal energy has been consumed!
Everything comes at a price. Despite your severe injuries, you have expended an excessive amount of power.
The status effect Exhaustion has been applied!
Strength, Stamina, and Agility have temporarily decreased drastically!

I felt the strength drain from my entire body. I could barely hear the System notification drilling into my ears—or the Skeleton Warlord’s shouts from inside my Inventory.

My body felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton, and only one thought kept circling through my cold, numb mind.

That was my last chance.

Why? Why hadn’t I known? Why hadn’t I guessed?

The Arch Lich had clearly said he had watched me through Familiars planted throughout the battlefield.

Then I should have accounted for the fact that I had used One Annihilation against the Liches and Death Knights on my way here.

Even if I could not be certain, I should at least have suspected it.

Idiot.

A self-deprecating laugh escaped me. I had sworn not to let my guard down… yet at the most important moment, I had made my greatest mistake.

Having no other choice was no excuse. A fight was not about the process, but the result.

And this was what letting my guard down had earned me.

Clang!

The iron spear slipped between my fingers and rolled across the ground. My legs, drained of strength, slowly gave way.

As I sank to my knees and lowered my head, a deep darkness fell over me.

“You, human. How does it feel to pay the price for your reckless bravado?”

I barely managed to raise my head and met a pair of burning red eye-lights. A voice squeezed through my cracked lips.

“Of course it feels like shit, you fucking bastard.”

“It was a fearsome strike. I shall commend you for that much.”

The Arch Lich’s voice was steeped in triumph.

Even his teleportation magic had not allowed him to evade One Annihilation completely. His left arm was gone.

But in the end, he was the one standing here as the victor.

The red eye-lights looking down at me, kneeling like a criminal, glimmered with joy.

“I waited until the very end. I restrained myself and endured the humiliation of suffering at a human’s hands. And at last… victory belongs to me.”

Smart. Cunning.

Just as I had thought, he had been waiting for me to use One Annihilation from the very beginning.

Earlier, I had swept away the Liches and Death Knights with One Annihilation, then recovered my stamina by leveling up. But the Arch Lich had not missed the fact that the attack had exhausted all my strength in an instant.

“Do you understand now? This is your limit. The limit of humanity.”

Limit.

That one word pierced deep into my chest.

The limit called F-rank, which I had been unable to escape no matter how hard I worked. The very limit I had continued to break through day after day after obtaining the System.

Is this really as far as I go?

I had worked myself nearly to death. For my own sake, and for the people I loved. No matter what danger came at me, I gritted my teeth and fought my way through it.

That was how I had lived.

Every step had been part of breaking through my limits.

“It’s not… over yet.”

The voice that slipped between my lips sounded like it belonged to someone else, utterly devoid of life.

I looked up at the Arch Lich through hazy eyes.

"What?"

"I said it's not over yet."

A life-and-death duel ended only when one of the two combatants fell.

So this fight was not over.

Only when one of us finally died would whoever remained standing be the victor.

I mumbled in my dazed state.

Inventory open. Summon.

One of the spears stored in my Inventory appeared in my hand.

No—I thought I had caught it, but it slipped from my grasp at once.

Clang!

The truth struck me again.

I no longer had the strength to hold a spear, much less the energy to swing one.

"Kehat! Kahahahah!"

The Arch Lich burst into wild laughter at the sight of me.

But I did not give up.

I couldn't.

Inventory open. Summon.

I kept summoning weapons.

Clang!

And kept dropping them.

Inventory open. Summon.

Clang!

"Human. You foolish, stupid human!"

Even as the Arch Lich mocked me, I never stopped.

The courage to humbly accept death? If that was what people called courage, I would rather be a coward.

I would… survive. No matter what.

I believed that was the final courtesy I owed the life I had fought so hard to live—and the right answer.

Inventory open. Summon.

At that very moment—

Ding.

SYSTEM

Endurance has increased drastically.
The attribute Endurance has changed into Will!
Those with strong wills are not easily broken, nor do they fall. They will keep their will burning until the very end and fight with every ounce of their strength.
A strong will can sometimes produce the power to transcend one's limits!
The special effect Indomitable has manifested. All attributes temporarily increase slightly, and fatigue is reduced!

I felt warmth spreading from deep within me.

Compared to the power I had once possessed, it was infinitesimal. Yet somehow, it was warmer than anything else.

It was the System's answer to my desperate plea.

My final chance.

With my hand still trembling, I tightened my grip around the cold spear shaft.

"You…"

I was not the only one who noticed the change.

The Arch Lich had been watching me as though I were a monkey in a zoo, but now his eye-lights widened. At that moment, I gathered every scrap of strength I had and hurled myself forward.

In a world slowed to a crawl, I thrust the spear toward the Arch Lich standing tall before me.

Fwooooooosh!

As the spearhead tore through the air with a piercing shriek, I saw it clearly.

The Arch Lich's eye-lights curved like crescent moons.

He was mocking me.

"Blood Explosion."

Boom!

An explosion.

Then a shock tore through my entire body.

My body, hurtling forward with every ounce of strength I possessed, abruptly locked up. The spear slipped from my hand and buried itself diagonally in the ground.

I blinked with both eyes, their tiny blood vessels burst. In a world dyed entirely red, something sticky and wet fell from the air and touched my face.

Drip. Drip-drip-drip.

…Ah.

Blood.

Blood had erupted from my entire body like a fountain and was now raining down around me.

I raised an arm that trembled like an aspen leaf and saw ragged flesh and stark-white bone.

Blood Explosion.

An explosion of blood.

Beyond my fading consciousness, I heard the Skeleton Warlord cry out.

"…Human!"

How long had he been shouting?

I wanted to answer, but all that spilled between my lips was blood mixed with bits of my organs.

"Cough."

My vision spun.

I reached toward the Arch Lich, barely visible through the blood covering my face, but I could neither touch him nor reach him.

Perhaps I never would.

"Get a hold of yourself! You have to live!"

Like that needed saying.

Of course I did.

I had to survive, defeat the Arch Lich, and return to the place where I belonged.

But…

Could I really do that?

At that moment, the world slowly began to tilt.

No. The world was still.

I was the one tilting.

Unable to withstand the unending blood loss and injuries, my body was finally giving out.

No. If I fall, it's all over.

I forced my already broken ankle to hold me upright.

The faint pain, no sharper than a thorn prick, was proof that I was dying. The Skeleton Warlord's shouts, breaking through the static like a bad radio signal, were proof that I was still alive.

"…do it, human! Hurry!"

Do what? What?

"Summon me right n—!"

My ruptured eardrums and fading consciousness could not make out the Skeleton Warlord's words.

Even if I had heard him clearly, I could not have stopped what the Arch Lich did next.

"You possess an interesting item."

At some point, a familiar object had appeared in the Arch Lich's hand.

White Flame, my beloved spear that had accompanied me through countless battles, flared in a stranger's grasp.

But even as his finger bones burned, the Arch Lich merely laughed.

"I have received an extravagant gift. I should return it to its owner now."

The Arch Lich drew back his arm. Powerful mana suppressed White Flame's flames and surged toward the spearhead.

"Farewell, new Adversary—or perhaps merely a foolish human who might have been the Adversary."

Fwoosh!

The sound of the spear cutting through the air was brief.

The moment felt eternal.

I silently watched White Flame streak toward me like a flash of light. Countless possibilities raced through my mind before I finally reached a conclusion.

I can't dodge it.

Then only one ending remained.

Death.

I had fought countless battles over the past seven years, but never had the word *death* felt so close.

All I could do was watch it approach.

Yeah. It's over.

The instant I calmly repeated those words to myself—

Crack!

White Flame's spearhead shattered bone and punched through the center of a chest.

My eyes flew wide, and I froze.

Not from pain.

From shock.

"You…"

"What?"

Unable to find the words, I stared at the blue eye-lights flickering inches from my face.

The Skeleton Warlord, previously no more than a skull the size of a soccer ball, now stood two meters[2016] tall. He spoke in his usual gruff voice.

“Do not ask how I managed to come out on my own. This commander has no idea, either.”

“Then why? Why did you…”

I looked at him as I asked.

The spearhead had pierced the Skeleton Warlord’s back and chest, stopping exactly one handspan away from me.

If no one had blocked it, it would have killed me and then some.

The Skeleton Warlord had thrown himself in front of me and saved my life.

“…I do not know that either. Damn it. I do not know anything anymore. Perhaps this sword bewitched me.”

Only then did I recognize the sword in the Skeleton Warlord’s hand.

“Hero’s Soul.”

Lei Fei’s only remaining keepsake.

A sword that could not even be held by someone unworthy of becoming a hero.

That very Hero’s Soul was now in the Skeleton Warlord’s hand.

In the hand of a Named Monster that was not even human.

“Hero’s Soul. That is a decent name for something named by humans. No, to be honest, it is cool. It is a shame I was too late to swing it properly…”

The Skeleton Warlord’s voice faded.

The light was slowly disappearing from his blue eye-lights, which had always shone so clearly.

I knew what this meant.

Erasure.

There was no doubt.

Even now, the Arch Lich’s mana carried within White Flame’s spearhead was rapidly eating away at the Skeleton Warlord.

“You…”

“Say no more. I already regret this enough as it is.”

I did not believe him.

His words were gruff, but I heard the quiet laugh behind them.

“Human. There is something I wish to ask.”

The Arch Lich was approaching beyond the Skeleton Warlord’s slowly crumbling shoulder, but I silently nodded.

“Anything.”

After hesitating for a moment, the Skeleton Warlord asked in a small voice,

[2016] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

“What you said last time. Did you mean it?”

“Last time? What did I…? Ah.”

I suddenly remembered.

It had been right after Lei Fei’s death, when the Skeleton Warlord was thinking about the past he could no longer remember.

And the words I had casually tossed his way.

“Well, I think he was probably a pretty decent guy.”

“…Huh? Were you saying that to this commander?”

“No. Just talking to myself.”

“Ahem. Right?”

So that was why.

That was what it had been about.

For the Skeleton Warlord, who had awakened after drawing strength from a spirit that had lost all its memories, I might have been his only friend—the one who had always been by his side.

One small remark I had tossed out like a pebble had sent ripples through the pond of his heart.

What an idiot.

Why did that matter? Why was one little thing worth going this far?

For a moment, I could not speak. Something hot rose inside me, but I forced it down and barely managed to answer.

“Of course I meant it.”

“Yes. I see.”

The Skeleton Warlord’s flickering blue eye-lights curved into a smile.

At that very moment, a chilling voice rang out and brought everything to an end.

“Have you finished saying your farewells?”

“…!”

“Bone Explosion.”

Boom!

I instinctively crossed both arms over my face. The impact swept through my entire body and sent me flying.

When I barely managed to push myself upright, I saw a skull soaring high into the air and bones shattering into countless pieces.

And…

That was all.

The Skeleton Warlord was nowhere to be seen.

Thud!

Hero’s Soul fell from the air and plunged deep into the ground.

Along with the hand of someone who had never released its hilt, even at the very end.

Chapter 425

Clang-clatter!

White Flame, having lost its target, rolled across the ground.

Ah.

The Arch Lich snapped his fingers at me as I stood frozen like a statue. A pair of black hands materialized in midair and constricted around my entire body.

He no longer needed an incantation to cast his magic.

Step. Step.

With every step the Arch Lich took, something seeped into various parts of his body, which was as hazy as mist.

The left arm that had vanished in One Annihilation slowly regenerated, while his shattered, fractured bones knit back together, sturdier than before and gleaming with an even darker hue.

The closer the Gate came to completion, the stronger the Arch Lich became.

—So there was a reason I smelled death upon you. Friendship between a human and a monster… How touching.

Crack.

I heard bones shifting out of place throughout my body, but I stared blankly over the Arch Lich's shoulder.

More precisely, at the sword buried in the ground—and the hand of someone who had held on to its hilt until the very end.

The Skeleton Warlord.

Humans and monsters were sworn enemies, as ordained by God.

The same had been true of me and the Skeleton Warlord. At least, it had been at first.

But… now I finally understood. At some point, the Skeleton Warlord had stopped being a monster to me.

If I'd still thought of him as a monster, I would've erased him with my own hands.

If I had killed the Skeleton Warlord myself, the resulting level-up might have given me one last hope.

But I had hesitated, and ultimately given up.

Not because he had saved my life. Because in my heart, I had already accepted him as a friend.

A hollow laugh escaped me.

Damn it. I never should've gotten attached.

The Arch Lich's eye-lights narrowed at the sight of me.

—Are you laughing? In a situation like this?

“My mother used to say that fortune comes to those who smile.”

—You have lost your mind.

“Why the fuck do you care if I laugh? What are you, my immediate senior in the army?”

I spat toward the Arch Lich’s face. A thick liquid, impossible to distinguish as blood or phlegm, trickled down between his brows.

At the same time, the red eye-lights in the places where his eyes should have been flared violently.

—I heard your answer clearly.

“Go eat a dick.”

It would have been a lie to say I had no regrets about the life I had lived, but none of that mattered now. Regret always came too late, and I had fought until the bitter end.

I had done enough.

Once I let go of everything, it all felt like one long dream. My face, smiling peacefully at the Arch Lich’s eye-lights, was reflected in them.

—I told you, did I not? Your flesh would be torn to pieces, and your soul would wander the River of Death forever.

I readily nodded in agreement.

“I guess so. Just like that Demon King bastard you serve.”

—…!

“If I run into him, I’ll give him your regards. What’s his address?”

—…We shall see how long you can continue spouting such nonsense.

At the Arch Lich’s gesture, the enormous hands of mana squeezing me seized all four of my limbs. Then they began pulling my body apart with tremendous force.

Slowly.

Little by little.

Crack. Craaack.

Small ruptures sounded inside me, and the sensation of pain I had momentarily forgotten awakened.

I thought I no longer had the strength even to scream, but a cry tore itself from between my lips.

“Gnh… graaaaagh!”

—That sounds much better.

Pain bleached my vision white. I let out all the screams I had been holding back and waited for death to come.

But when even the pain began to fade, what came for me was not death.

It was a System notification.

Beep.

SYSTEM

High-grade Potion has been used!
The amount of potion used is too small. Your injuries have been healed slightly!
Your injuries are extremely severe. You require a greater amount of higher-quality healing than this!

…What?

A cool sensation spread through me, and the pain surged back to life. My eyes flew open.

The Arch Lich was staring at me with mockery gleaming in his eye-lights.

And in his hand was a glass bottle.

That's…

It was one of the potions that had been in Lee Jungryong's subspace pocket—the one the Arch Lich had stolen long ago.

And now he was using a potion made for healing as an instrument of torture.

Just enough healing to keep me poised at the threshold of death.

Just enough to make me feel the greatest possible pain.

—Foolish human. Did you truly think this body would grant you such an easy, peaceful death?

"…!"

—Continue to howl. Weep like a coward and writhe in agony. Only once you have realized your folly shall you be permitted to cross into the River of Death.

The Arch Lich shook the glass bottle, his voice thick with mockery.

Not even a tenth of the potion was gone. The amount that remained represented all the pain I had yet to endure.

Time would crawl by without end, each moment stretching into an eternity.

Weak healing spread through my body, but so did pain that came crashing down over every inch of me. My breathing grew ragged. I forced a smile and asked the Arch Lich,

"If I give three cheers for the Demon King, will you finish me off sooner?"

—Perhaps. If you do so with sufficient passion and sincerity, I may consider it.

"I'm not doing that, you son of a bitch."

—Very well. We have plenty of time, after all. There is no harm in considering it at your leisure—

Crunch!

The Arch Lich's eye-lights trembled.

So did I.

Neither of us had expected what happened next.

No one had.

—…What is this?

With a doubtful voice, the Arch Lich looked down at his chest.

Light.

It was light. A dazzling radiance bright enough to illuminate the entire world had burst through his chest.

No. That isn't light.

I stared at it with vacant eyes.

It was a sword, shining more brilliantly than ever before.

I knew the name of that all-too-familiar sword.

Hero's Soul.

And I knew the owner of the hand wrapped tightly around its hilt beyond the Arch Lich's skeletal chest.

"…!"

It was as if the entire world had stopped moving.

In that impossibly slowed world, I watched hundreds—thousands—of bone fragments gather.

They had been nothing more than the last traces someone had left behind, but now they pulled toward one another and began taking shape.

Click. Clack!

Bones fused together.

Two arms and two legs formed first, followed by a chest and abdomen.

The black sheen washed from the bones beneath the radiance spilling from Hero's Soul. Before long, they had taken on a soft golden hue, growing longer and sturdier.

Ah.

It was an astonishing sight.

Countless fragments of bone gathered to form a body, as though time itself were flowing backward. The light streaming from the sword drove the darkness from every joint, heralding the birth of a new being.

And finally, when a skull settled onto the completed body—

Flash!

Golden eye-lights burst from its empty sockets.

The feeling was both utterly familiar and completely strange.

The next moment, a voice rang out, and the time that had stopped began to flow again.

—You asked me why, did you not?

"…!"

My body trembled as if lightning had pierced through me. A memory from less than an hour ago flashed through my mind.

Then why, exactly?

Yes. That was what I had asked back then.

Why had he saved me? Why had he chosen to become my shield even though he had been prepared to face Erasure?

He had said he did not know. He did not know why he had done such a thing. Perhaps the sword had bewitched him.

And now, the answer I had not heard then pierced my ears.

—Because though you are devious, you are a pretty decent human. That was all.

A pretty decent guy.

Words I had once said to someone.

I stared at him in disbelief.

His faintly golden body was larger and sturdier than before. An unknown silver pattern was engraved across the forehead of his skull, resembling a crown.

No.

It was unmistakably a crown.

The moment I saw the System window hovering above his head, a hollow laugh escaped me.

"Look how much you've grown, Bones."

—No wonder I have felt itchy all over for so long.

The small black caterpillar had finally shed its skin and spread its wings.

The Skeleton Warlord—or rather, the Skeleton King's eye-lights curved like crescent moons.

He was smiling.

So was I.

And there was one being who could not smile.

—Graaaagh! Graaaaaaaaaagh!

The Arch Lich.

The unprecedented Named Monster, who commanded hundreds of thousands of undead and possessed inexhaustible, tremendous mana, writhed in agony.

A single sword had pierced straight through the center of his chest.

The golden radiance flowing from Hero's Soul devoured his mana and melted his body.

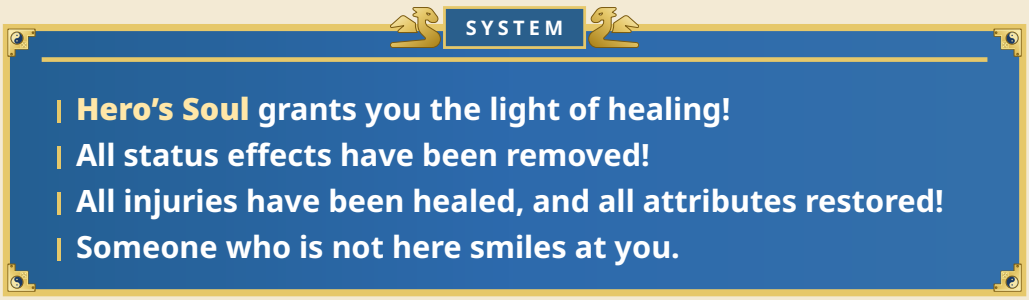
Perhaps even his soul.

—Human.

At the Skeleton King's quiet call, I realized what I had to do.

Now… let's finish this.

Beep.



Fwooooooosh!

A pillar of light burst from Hero's Soul and enveloped me.

Gentle warmth flooded my body. Shattered bones knit together, torn flesh healed, and my damaged organs and meridians[2017] recovered. At the same time, heat seethed through me like lava, ready to erupt at any moment.

I can do this.

The certainty was so absolute that it surprised even me.

And it was true.

With this strength, there was nothing I could not do.

Come.

Fwooooooosh! Clack!

At the same time that I pulled White Flame, rolling across the ground, into my hand—

Fwoosh!

I thrust out my foot, feeling myself rise into the air.

At the end of that step stood the Arch Lich, writhing in agony as streams of tremendous mana poured from his body.

—What in the world! What magic have you used?!

The Arch Lich spotted me and shrieked in a frenzy.

His red eye-lights shook wildly, swelling larger and larger.

That alone told me how much pain he was in.

—Damn you! Damn you, human! Graaaaagh!

Instead of answering, I slowly raised White Flame.

[2017] In traditional East Asian medicine, meridians are pathways through which qi is understood to flow.

I aimed its transparent spearhead at the Arch Lich, whose limbs were trembling violently from the pain, and at the enormous Gate looming behind him.

Whoosh.

The fire dragon spread its wings and soared from my dantian, transforming into a ball of flame as it surged through every limb and bone in my body. It flowed along my fingertips, kindling blue flames atop White Flame's spearhead and layering them over and over.

—You cur! How dare you—

The Arch Lich flailed his arms and legs in a frenzy, but the magic he fired collided with the heat surrounding me like a barrier and vanished before it could even reach me.

Unlike the weakened Arch Lich, however, the darkness around the Gate churned with ever greater violence.

And at last, I realized.

Now!

White Flame trembled as rotational force traveled up through my leg, waist, shoulder, and wrist.

The unprecedented surge of qi drawn from my entire body kindled flames larger than ever before.

Yes.

This was the moment.

Fwoosh.

One step.

All the space separating the Arch Lich and me vanished, and time slowed.

Before the Arch Lich's slowly moving lips could finish the incantation, I launched a single strike filled with every ounce of my will and strength.

—Blink…!

One Annihilation.

There would be no second mistake.

The blue fire dragon bursting from White Flame's spearhead swallowed both the Arch Lich and the Gate.

Kwooooooooooong!

Chapter 426

Fwooooooosh!

The instant the Arch Lich faced the enormous fire dragon that burst from the spearhead, it realized the truth.

Too late.

There was no avoiding this attack.

The Spell it had not yet managed to unleash and the magical power that had been on the verge of completion scattered beneath the flames rushing straight toward it.

The fire dragon, blazing with hellfire, opened its jaws at the Arch Lich, which had frozen in place, oblivious even to the pain.

Kwooooooong!

Blue flames swept in every direction with a thunderous roar like that of a dragon. The terrible heat distorted space and vaporized everything in its path.

The Arch Lich felt the magical power and barriers surrounding it melt away. It even felt a sensation it had long since forgotten.

It's hot.

Fwoosh!

Blue hellfire filled the Arch Lich's vision. The fire dragon swept over its entire body and continued onward without stopping.

Straight toward the enormous black door towering over the center of the ruined city.

The Gate.

No!

The Arch Lich's red eye-lights flared wide as it stretched out a hand, but no voice emerged. The fire dragon swallowed the Gate, which was as large as itself, whole.

The moment the unprecedented mass of magical power gathered from the life force of hundreds of thousands of humans collided with the flames, a blinding flash erupted.

Fwoosh!

A pillar of light rose into the sky, bright enough to be seen from hundreds, perhaps thousands, of kilometers[2018] away.

Darkness and blue flames collided with one another, then soon blended together. The forest of buildings that had been struggling to remain standing bent at the waist, and a ring of wind burst outward.

Krrrrooooom—

[2018] One kilometer is about 0.62 miles; 100 kilometers is about 62 miles, and 1,000 kilometers is about 620 miles.

A roar and tremor beyond description shook the world.

The gray sky split apart, and the dense fog blanketing the entire city scattered like heat haze.

Then, as though everything that had just happened were a distant dream, silence descended.

Ah.

The Arch Lich gazed hollowly upon the world.

The scene looked no different from before, but it knew. Everything had changed, itself included.

Everything had collapsed like a sandcastle.

The Arch Lich slowly turned its head. Its trembling red eye-lights settled on the lone figure standing tall as an iron tower.

—"I should have killed you."

The single sentence broke the silence.

Jin Taekyung opened his mouth, his complexion utterly bloodless. The accumulated damage and mental exhaustion from his endless battles made him look as though he might collapse at any moment, but his voice alone had not lost its strength.

"Yeah. You should've killed me sooner."

The Arch Lich fell silent.

It had no one but itself to blame for missing its chance to end Jin Taekyung's life.

One brief lapse in vigilance had reduced everything to nothing.

My king. Please forgive this disloyal servant.

The Arch Lich begged forgiveness from its king, wherever he might be.

If it had killed Jin Taekyung without delay… If the monster that had sided with the human had not been reborn as a new being and driven that damned sword into its chest…

Everything would have gone according to plan.

It would have survived and completed the Gate. At the head of an unimaginably vast monster army, it would have hunted down those verminous humans, slaughtered them, and burned the city to the ground.

All while awaiting the great king's eventual return.

But the plan it had believed perfect had fallen apart spectacularly.

All because of a single human.

Jin Taekyung.

The Arch Lich's fading red eye-lights flared with the last of their strength.

A vow to itself and an oath of vengeance spilled toward Jin Taekyung.

—"Remember me. Remember this body, which will one day trample your souls beneath its bare feet."

Jin Taekyung spat out a wad of phlegm.

“Big talk from a bastard who’s about to croak. Go on. Say, ‘Asmodeus[2019] is a fucking son of a bitch.‘”

The Skeleton King hesitantly opened its mouth.

—“Asmodeus[2020] is a fucking son of a bitch…”

“…Not you.”

—“Ah, I know. I just wanted to try it once. But I cannot say that I feel good after uttering something so blasphemous.”

“What’s the problem? You’re a king now, too.”

—“Oh. That is true.”

I swear upon the River of Death that I will tear those two apart.

The Arch Lich stretched both hands toward Jin Taekyung and the Skeleton King.

Its skeletal hands clenched as if they would crush the two figures standing far away, but nothing happened.

Instead, a wind that had blown in from somewhere brushed against its entire body.

Whooooooosh.

It was collapse.

Beginning with its hands, which turned to ash and scattered, everything that made up the Arch Lich began to crumble.

Its arms. Its legs. Its chest.

And finally, even the skull housing its red eye-lights.

—“Please survive. Until the day we meet again…”

Its final voice, filled with resentment, vanished into the wind.

The wind grew stronger and swept onward, carrying the ashes of what had once been the Arch Lich.

Everything caught within the range of One Annihilation sank and crumbled wherever the wind passed. High-rise buildings, heaps of concrete, overturned cars, and corpses long since emptied of life…

Even the enormous, unfinished Gate that would have marked the beginning of an even greater war.

Fssshhh.

As Jin Taekyung silently watched it all, clear chimes rang in his ears—sounds that only he could hear.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Countless System messages filled his vision. They were a victory salute announcing that everything was finally over.

[2019] Asmodeus is a demon king.

[2020] Asmodeus is a demon king.

But Jin Taekyung had already exhausted every last bit of his strength, and his body was tipping toward the ground.

I did it.

With that final thought, a deep and peaceful sleep overtook him.

The Skeleton King carefully caught Jin Taekyung as he fell and saw the faint smile on his lips.

—"…You worked hard."

Devious though he may be, he really is a pretty decent human.

Murmuring inwardly, the Skeleton King was about to carry Jin Taekyung somewhere safe and comfortable when it remembered something.

—"Ah, right. The sword."

Was it called Hero's Soul?

It did not know who had named it, but there was no doubt that the sword held a mysterious power.

That sword had awakened it from the brink of Erasure when it had still been the Skeleton Warlord. It was also thanks to the sword that it had managed to deal such a devastating blow to the terrifying Arch Lich.

—"I almost forgot. I need to make sure to keep it safe."

It did not take long to find. The sword that had remained embedded in its target's chest until the very end lay quietly where the Arch Lich had stood only moments ago.

But after picking up **Hero's Soul**, the Skeleton King tilted its head.

—"Huh? Something feels strange."

It was a peculiar sensation, difficult to explain.

It could not quite put its finger on it, but… how should it describe the feeling? The sword was undeniably a fine blade, yet it no longer possessed the same mysterious quality as before.

—"Did I pick up the wrong sword?"

But no matter how thoroughly the Skeleton King searched the area or examined the blade, nothing changed.

It scratched its golden skull and pondered the matter for a while before finally reaching a conclusion.

—"Hmm. I guess this is it."

It was probably just a fleeting impression. The sword looked exactly as it remembered, and it had seen the weapon fall from the Arch Lich's chest with its own eyes.

Then why does this feel so unsettling?

It made no sense at all.

The Skeleton King shook its head and slid the sword between its pelvic bones for safekeeping.

As it headed toward the unconscious Jin Taekyung, it remained unaware of what had happened the moment Jin Taekyung exhausted all his strength and lost consciousness.

Mist-like black energy had mingled with the wind scattering into the distance.

And the golden light dwelling within **Hero's Soul** had left the sword to pursue it.

But one being was different.

The black energy drifted away on the wind.

Reduced by Jin Taekyung to a tiny, powerless fragment of a soul, the Arch Lich stared wide-eyed at the dazzling golden light blocking its path.

This is impossible.

The words it had spoken to Jin Taekyung and the Skeleton King before losing its form had contained no trace of falsehood.

It would return in the near future. With even greater power and an even larger army of monsters, it would stain this land with blood.

Life Force Vessel.

The highest order of black magic available only to the undead—a vessel capable of preserving a fragment of the soul.

So long as it had that, the Arch Lich could escape eternal Erasure.

Or so it had believed, until that brilliant golden light barred its way.

—"You… What are you?"

The Arch Lich was now only a pitiful fragment of a soul, utterly insignificant compared to the power emanating from the light.

The black energy writhed violently with rage, confusion, and fear.

Yet even though the Arch Lich's thoughts reached it, the golden light did not respond. It merely shone brighter and swelled larger.

Then, in the next moment, the Arch Lich realized what the light truly was.

That is not magic. It is a soul.

The soul of someone it had once shattered and trampled beneath its feet. A fragment of a soul that had lost even its form, yet remained within the sword through sheer will alone.

Suddenly, the Arch Lich recalled a memory it had buried deep within its mind.

"How noble, human. What is your name?"

That day, when blood had formed rivers and corpses had formed mountains.

One human had remained standing until the very end in a city filled with nothing but destruction and death.

—"Lei Fei."

The Arch Lich—or rather, the black energy—stopped dead.

A dazzling golden light burst through the air and swept over it like a wave.

Fwooooooosh!

…Damn it.

That was the Arch Lich’s final thought.

The battle raged fiercely around the main force.

While the S-rank Hunters had moved toward the rear with part of the army to clear a path for the suicide squad, the tens of thousands of monsters had seized the opportunity and charged.

“Fire Rain!”

Kwaaang!

The mage units in the rear unleashed an area-wide spell, and a rain of fire poured from the sky.

Hundreds of monsters burned to death, reduced to charred lumps. The mages clenched their fists at the sight.

Then—

Whooooooosh! Thwack!

“…Huh?”

One of the mages wiped the blood from their face with a bewildered expression.

The face of the comrade who had been smiling at them only moments ago was gone.

No—it had burst apart.

A black spear had crossed the distance like a beam of light and struck them.

Whooooooosh! Boom!

Another spear flew in and skewered six or seven mages like meat on a spit.

Only then did the belated screams erupt.

“Aaaaargh!”

“Death Knights! They’re Death Knights!”

“Fuck, what the hell are you talking about? Didn’t we take care of all of them?”

“I-I don’t think so! It looks like they hid their elites separately among the others!”

Those words soon proved true.

Having clearly recognized the absence of the S-rank Hunters, the elite monsters revealed themselves, and an unstoppable slaughter began.

Slash!

Kwaaang!

Death Knights, Liches, and dozens of Wyverns that had remained out of sight appeared and launched a ferocious assault.

People died without end, and monsters surged forward without pause.

With even the S-rank Hunters away from their positions, deep despair settled over the faces of those risking their lives to hold the line.

It’s all over.

Then, just as everyone thought of death—

Shiiiiing!

A Death Knight’s sword stopped in the middle of cutting through someone.

No.

It crumbled into ash.

“W-What the hell…?”

The Hunter who had narrowly escaped death looked around and gaped.

The sight before him was unbelievable.

First, hundreds fell.

Then thousands crumbled.

Before long, monsters numbering in the tens of thousands were turning to ash and scattering.

Whooooooosh.

At long last, the war was over.

Chapter 427

It was a winter night in December, and snow was pouring down in thick flurries.

People hurried through the streets, trusting the forecast that had confidently predicted unusually clear weather. They were bewildered, and the Meteorological Agency was thrown into confusion.

“What the hell? What’s going on?”

“We’re analyzing it now. This definitely shouldn’t be happening.”

“Snow the size of hailstones is pouring down, and you’re telling me it shouldn’t be happening? Stop spouting nonsense and bring me the data. We have real-time observations, don’t we?”

“We’re checking them now, but… Ah, it looks like an abnormal phenomenon caused by a sudden surge in mana in China’s Sichuan region. The expected snowfall is no joke.”

“Sichuan? Damn it. Is that Arch Lich bastard controlling the weather now, too?”

After the Great Cataclysm, the Meteorological Agency had incorporated various forms of magic and begun issuing forecasts that bordered on prophecy.

An hour after hastily conducting another round of observations, the agency issued a heavy-snow advisory across the country. They predicted record-breaking snowfall, the worst in roughly thirty years.

But before long, the people hurrying home had no choice but to stop in their tracks.

A single sentence rang out from the massive screen at the heart of an ordinary commercial district.

“On a day like today, it is both my pleasure and my honor to bring you this news.”

An elderly East Asian man appeared on the screen.

Behind him sat the leaders of the nations on the United Nations Security Council. The Chairman of the People’s Republic of China addressed the countless microphones, his eyes red and his voice thick with emotion.

“The Arch Lich has been erased. We… have won.”

Victory.

That one word was enough.

For roughly a month—thirty-four days, to be exact—an unprecedented monster wave had raged without pause.

The news that the great war, which had spread unease throughout the world beyond Sichuan Province, had finally come to an end left people standing there with their mouths hanging open.

Then they erupted into thunderous cheers.

“Waaaaaaah!”

“Wait! Hold on! I couldn’t hear that. What did he just say?”

“…It’s over!”

“What?”

“The subtitles! Look at the subtitles!”

“‘The Arch Lich has been erased’… Oh, shit, it’s true! Waaaaaaah! I thought I was going to get called up for reserve duty[2021]!”

They heard neither Chairman Xiao Yang’s thirty-minute announcement nor the additional explanation given afterward by the spokesperson for the United Nations Security Council.

With the Arch Lich erased, its countless undead legions had lost their power and been annihilated as well. At last, the peace everyone had longed for had arrived.

“Mom, it’s me. Yeah. Did you see the news? You didn’t? Turn it on right now. Yeah, yeah!”

“We have to celebrate. Assistant Manager Kim, let’s go for a third round!”

“A third round? The server update is tomorrow. Manager Noh is going to lose his shit.”

“Manager Noh is coming too. He’s bringing the corporate card.”

“Ugh, I don’t want to see that bastard’s face. Fine. Let’s go.”

“Unity![2022] Yes, Battalion Commander. This is Captain Lee Junbeom. Could I extend my leave by just one more day—? No, sir. I’m sorry, sir.”

People who had been going back and forth outside while desperately ignoring their unease ran to the bars amid the cheers. Even those who had stayed home, anticipating a second Great Cataclysm, poured into the streets and joined the festive atmosphere.

The cheering did not die down even after midnight.

Nor the next day, or the day after that…

The entire world boiled like a cauldron over a charcoal brazier at the news of this monumental victory, and fresh articles appeared day after day in every language.

People even joked that the victory had generated more coverage than the heavy snow that fell across Korea for three straight days.

And… there was one name that appeared without fail in every one of those articles.

[The New York Times, United States: “A Great Victory, a New Hero.”]

[The Times, United Kingdom: “A New Star Rising in the East. Is He Close to Prince Felix?”]

[2021] South Korea requires many people who have completed military service to attend periodic reserve training. The speaker feared being called up during the crisis.

[2022] “Unity” translates *dan-gyeol*, a military salute used when addressing a superior.

[Asahi Shimbun, Japan: “Jin Taekyung Is Asia’s Pride. But Japan’s First-String Hunters Could Surpass Him!”]

[People’s Daily, China: “The Young Korean Knight-Errant Who Saved Countless People. And the Tragic Death of Zhonghua’s[2023] Genius, Wu Heixing.”]

[China Youth News: “Jin Taekyung Is a Descendant of Chen Lin, a Ming Dynasty General. The Blood of Zhonghua[2024] Unmistakably Flows Through Him, and He Will Surely Become a Chinese Citizen Before Long.”]

[Goryeo Daily, Korea: “Ares Guild Vice Guild Master, Hunter Lee Jungryong, Age 68. Presumed Dead…”]

[Daspatch[2025] Korea official: “We have devoted every effort to investigating Jin Taekyung for several months, but we could not uncover a single thing. His romantic history is astonishingly clean.” When a reporter asked whether that meant he had dated many women but parted with each of them amicably, the official cut him off: “No. I mean he’s never dated anyone in his life.”]

To the various media outlets, Jin Taekyung was nothing short of a Christmas present.

Every spotlight turned toward him, and all kinds of stories about him came pouring out.

The material was endless. Needless to say, there was plenty to cover about the monster wave now known as the “Winter War,” but his past actions on the way to his current position and even the most trivial details of his private life were considered newsworthy.

Even the trashy articles that would normally have been cursed out as gutter journalism attracted interest.

That was how much of the world’s attention had turned toward the new hero who had led them to this great victory.

But not all that attention was positive.

Information had begun leaking out bit by bit from behind the ironclad internal security, and people began raising questions.

[Four Days After the War. What Was Hidden Behind That Great Victory? The Questions Surrounding Jin Taekyung.]

[Lee Jungryong Presumed Dead. Wu Heixing’s Suspicious Death. The Deaths of Two S-Rank Hunters and the Rise of a New Hero.]

[Secret Testimony from Coalition Commanders Who Were at the Scene: “Considering the ferocity of the battle, Jin Taekyung’s body showed no significant injuries when he was discovered. We are investigating whether he used potions. Once he regains consciousness, the full circumstances will become clear.”]

[2023] *Zhonghua* is a patriotic term for China and Chinese civilization.

[2024] *Zhonghua* is a patriotic term for China and Chinese civilization.

[2025] Daspatch alludes to Dispatch, a South Korean entertainment-news outlet known for reporting on celebrities’ private lives.

Although they remained a tiny minority, conspiracy theories began surfacing, and fierce arguments erupted across the internet.

The trashy articles soon vanished beneath a barrage of malicious comments and reports, but they planted doubts in the minds of some members of the public. Eventually, everyone's attention settled on one thing.

Jin Taekyung.

When, exactly, would he show himself?

Beep. Beep.

State-of-the-art medical equipment emitted mechanical sounds.

The people gathered in one part of the hospital room, which only a select few were permitted to enter, gazed worriedly at Jin Taekyung as he lay there wearing an oxygen mask.

"How is Mr. Jin's condition?"

Choi Minwoo answered Chairman Xiao Yang's question.

"It's always the same. Everything is perfectly normal, but for some reason, he still hasn't regained consciousness."

"Did both of them say that?"

"Yes. They said they don't know the cause."

"Hmm. If both of them said so, there can be no doubt… Then why on earth hasn't he regained consciousness?"

Chairman Xiao Yang sighed.

The two people he had mentioned were at the very top of their respective fields of medicine.

One was a civilian physician known as the reincarnation of Hua Tuo,[2026] while the other was one of the world's foremost healers.

If the two of them, invited to serve as Jin Taekyung's temporary attending physicians, had reached the same conclusion, there could be no doubt.

"I heard his family is here."

"The Peace Guild is taking good care of them. Fortunately, they've regained their composure."

"I see. Would it be possible for me to meet them, even briefly?"

"I can ask, but their wishes are what matter most, so…"

"I understand. Who could feel otherwise when a blood relative has yet to regain consciousness? I would appreciate it if you simply considered this the foolishness of an old man."

[2026] Hua Tuo was an ancient Chinese physician celebrated for his medical skill.

“No, Chairman. We’re grateful that you even thought of it.”

“Don’t thank me. If not for Mr. Jin, an even greater catastrophe would have occurred. I may be an old man without many years left, but I will carry this gratitude with me to the grave.”

Chairman Xiao Yang was sincere.

Four days had passed since that day. During that time, an investigation team made up of countless experts from around the world had combed through the city that had served as the Arch Lich’s base and discovered traces of the Gate.

Based on the enormous amount of residual mana, the projected scale of that Gate was nothing short of catastrophic.

“If Mr. Jin had failed to stop the Arch Lich that day, not only our country but all of Asia would have become a battlefield. No… Perhaps the entire world could have become one.”

“It was certainly possible.”

It might have been a slight exaggeration, but most of it was true.

So Choi Minwoo did not bother denying it. He simply nodded.

The praise was not directed at him, so he had no reason to feel embarrassed. Nor did he see any reason to diminish the gratitude felt by the leader of a nation with a population of more than a billion.

A debt of gratitude had a way of returning as an even greater gift.

“But Chairman, I’ve been hearing some unfavorable rumors about Jin Taekyung lately… Were you aware of them?”

“Do you mean inside the country or outside it?”

“Inside. The leadership of the Communist Party—or, more precisely, the Crown Prince Party.[2027]”

Chairman Xiao Yang nodded.

“I am fully aware of the matter.”

It concerned Wu Heixing’s death.

The investigation team had found his body severely mutilated, and conspiracy theories about it were gradually spreading both inside and outside the country.

“There are people who suspect Mr. Jin. They point to the fact that he had a minor argument with Wu Heixing during their first meeting, as well as the fact that Mr. Jin had no notable injuries when he was first discovered.”

There were two negative theories about what had happened.

The first claimed that Jin Taekyung, who had long harbored ill feelings toward Wu Heixing, had killed him and disguised it as the Arch Lich’s work.

[2027] The Crown Prince Party refers to a faction of Chinese political elites associated with the descendants of senior Communist Party figures, not a royal party.

The second claimed that Jin Taekyung and Lee Jungryong, who was now presumed missing or dead, had used Wu Heixing as a shield and seized the opportunity to kill the Arch Lich.

Chairman Xiao Yang knew about these theories and had already reached his own conclusion.

The old statesman spoke to Choi Minwoo in a firm tone.

“They are nothing more than absurd slander and conspiracy theories.”

“Thank you for believing him, but…”

It was a good response, but it was not enough.

Choi Minwoo continued slowly.

“The leader of the Crown Prince Party[2028] doesn’t seem to share your view, Chairman.”

It was a conspiracy theory condemned even within China as an embarrassment to the nation. But to a father who had lost his son, it sounded entirely plausible.

Wu Heixing’s father was the head of the Crown Prince Party,[2029] which constituted half of the Chinese Communist Party.

A political giant comparable to the Chairman himself, he had begun spreading the rumors in earnest. He had even formed an independent investigation team to dig into the matter.

“If Mr. Jin regains consciousness, the truth will come to light anyway. But for a high-ranking politician to take the lead in spreading such an absurd conspiracy theory…”

Choi Minwoo let his voice trail off, and Chairman Xiao Yang smiled faintly.

He has no qualms at all.

No matter how great a feat he had accomplished, the young man before him had lived a very different life and stood in a very different position from his own.

Yet the young man before him was pressing his point without hesitation, carefully controlling his pace and tone as he did so.

Was that information true?

As Chairman Xiao Yang suddenly recalled Choi Minwoo’s personal information, he tapped the armrest of his chair.

“Very well. It seems my explanation was insufficient, so let me say it again.”

“I’m listening.”

“My comrades and I already know everything about the matter, and we have completed all the necessary preparations.”

“All the necessary preparations…?”

[2028] The Crown Prince Party refers to a faction of Chinese political elites associated with the descendants of senior Communist Party figures, not a royal party.

[2029] The Crown Prince Party refers to a faction of Chinese political elites associated with the descendants of senior Communist Party figures, not a royal party.

“Before he can appeal to anyone about his son’s death, he will be standing trial.”

The Arch Lich was not the only one brought down by this war.

Corruption and embezzlement involving astronomical sums had been exposed, and dealing with the fallout would force the Crown Prince Party[2030] to tear out its own foundations.

Only then did a faint smile appear on Choi Minwoo’s lips.

“Does that answer your question?”

“More than enough.”

That was all he needed from today’s conversation.

A short while later, after exchanging a few more words, Chairman Xiao Yang left the room. Now alone, Choi Minwoo suddenly spoke.

“That’s what he says.”

And then one person’s eyes snapped open.

“Oh, fuck. I thought I was going to die from how stifling this was.”

[2030]The Crown Prince Party refers to a faction of Chinese political elites associated with the descendants of senior Communist Party figures, not a royal party.

Chapter 428

I sat up and released the breath I'd been holding.

"God, I'm dying."

Pretending to be unconscious for four days took a considerable amount of patience.

Especially while hooked up to a whole array of state-of-the-art medical equipment.

Besides, it wasn't exactly a good time to return to Murim.

Even if I went back, I'd just be stuck aboard the swift ship, staring stupidly at the Yangtze.

I was better off wrapping things up properly in the modern world. As long as I had the System, time was on my side.

Crack. Crack.

As I rolled my stiff neck from side to side, Team Leader Choi let out a quiet laugh.

"If anyone had seen this on CCTV, there would've been quite an uproar."

"That's a terrible thing to say. If that had happened, I would've bitten my tongue and killed myself."

Fortunately, there were no CCTV cameras, so my tongue was safe.

Then again, I was wearing a brain-wave detector that alerted the medical staff the instant a patient regained consciousness. CCTV would've been redundant.

"I have to ask—how on earth did you fool that machine?"

I shrugged.

"Oh, the brain-wave detector? This isn't a machine."

"Excuse me?"

"Well, it is, but the thing actually powering it is a Magic Gem."

"Then did you use mana…? No, internal energy?"

"Yeah. I made it malfunction. A little adjustment like that wasn't difficult."

After opening my Middle Dantian this time, my control over my internal energy had improved tremendously.

If I couldn't even fool a few medical devices, I would've been so frustrated that I'd have gone to check the temperature of the Han River[2031].

"Anyway, what do you think will happen with the Wu Heixing situation? From what Grandpa Jongseok said, it sounds like he's made preparations."

"This must be the fiftieth time I've told you: he isn't Grandpa Jongseok. He's Chairman Xiao."

"What's wrong with Grandpa Jongseok? It sounds nice and friendly."

"…Sigh."

[2031] "Checking the temperature of the Han River" is a dark allusion to jumping into the river to die.

Shaking his head, Team Leader Choi picked up an apple from the fruit basket beside him.

He drew a dagger that looked expensive at a glance, peeled the apple with practiced ease, and held it out to me.

“I don’t think you need to worry about Wu Heixing. Public opinion is on our side, and Chairman Xiao seems to have been sharpening his blade.”

“Chairman Xiao? Honestly, he seemed a little soft to me.”

Crunch.

I bit into the firm apple, and sweet juice filled my mouth.

If Chairman Xiao Yang had been as hard as this apple, the Crown Prince Party wouldn’t have remained at the center of power for so long.

As if he had read my mind, Team Leader Choi said, “Did you know Chairman Xiao was once branded a reactionary and sentenced to five years of hard labor in a pig slaughterhouse?”

“That happened?”

“I heard the Crown Prince Party targeted him when he tried to push through political reforms after the Great Cataclysm. But look where he is now.”

That told me everything I needed to know.

Chairman Xiao had a personal grudge against the Crown Prince Party, and after enduring years of hardship, he had risen to the highest position in the country. In other words, he had an iron will.

“When the time comes, a blade sharpened for years has to be swung. To the Crown Prince Party, Chairman Xiao will be the most dangerous swordsman of all.”

“Then Wu Heixing’s father…”

“Considering his political standing and the public sympathy surrounding Wu Heixing, execution is unlikely. He’ll probably be sent to a political prison camp or a pig slaughterhouse. But given his age, he’ll spend the rest of his life there.”

First Wu Heixing, and now his father.

So this was how father and son met their end.

It wasn’t my imagination. The apple really did taste sweeter today.

I grinned and wiped the juice from the corner of my mouth.

“Lying here for four days was worth it.”

Team Leader Choi peeled a second apple and handed it to me.

“Your judgment was correct. If the press had learned that you woke up after only half a day, there would’ve been no avoiding suspicion.”

According to the news Team Leader Choi had given me, Lee Jungryong had not even left behind a body, and his death was considered certain by the public. Wu Heixing, who had died with his neck broken, had been caught in the aftermath of the battle and discovered as a gruesome corpse.

If I'd woken up perfectly fine after half a day under those circumstances, the press would've had a field day tearing me apart.

"When you first woke up, even I had trouble regaining my composure… Had you already anticipated all this before you dealt with those two?"

I answered while biting into the apple.

"I didn't think that far."

"What?"

"No, my body was tired and my head hurt, so I just told them not to announce it yet. If people found out I was awake, there'd be hell to pay inside and out."

"…"

"What?"

Team Leader Choi stared at me as though I'd betrayed him, then quietly looked away.

"…It's nothing."

"Come on, lose the wounded expression. The result is what matters."

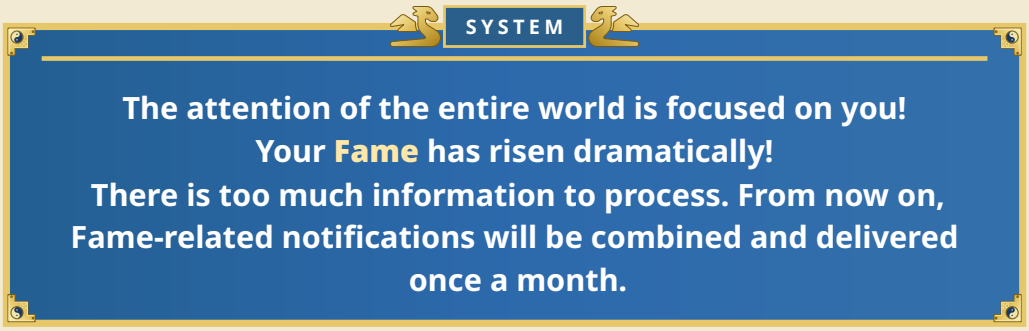
Just as I said, the result couldn't have turned out better for us.

Never mind Wu Heixing and the Crown Prince Party. We had legally eliminated our greatest obstacle, Lee Jungryong, and prevented an even greater catastrophe by defeating the Arch Lich.

The praise and adoration of people around the world were just a bonus.

I'd heard the notification about my Fame rising so many times that it was starting to drive me insane.

Like right now.



"…You should've done that from the start, you bastard."

The sigh slipped out before I could stop it, and Team Leader Choi tilted his head.

"Pardon?"

"Oh, it's nothing. More importantly, how's my family?"

My mother and Hayeon had arrived in China only a few hours earlier aboard a chartered plane sent under Chairman Xiao Yang's special orders. They had even been escorted by dozens of fighter jets, receiving treatment beyond that afforded to a state guest.

"You don't need to worry. Your mother is resting, and your younger sister…"

"You don't have to tell me about her. She'll be fine on her own."

"…Ah. Yes."

I couldn't bring myself to keep my condition secret from my family, so I'd had Team Leader Choi quietly tell them that I was completely unharmed and already awake.

Even so, I was worried about their first visit, which was coming up soon.

One or two smacks on the back won't settle this.

I'd rather fight several thousand monsters.

I'd left nothing but a single message in the family group chat saying I was going to China. Just imagining the fallout sent a chill down my spine.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes?"

"When my family comes to visit, you absolutely cannot go anywhere. Understood?"

"…?"

"Promise me you'll stay right beside me and protect me."

"Ah. All right."

And two hours later—

"You little brat! You little braaaat!"

"Mom!"

"M-Ma'am!"

Team Leader Choi stepped in front of my mother as she charged at me with a tearful roar unlike anything I had ever heard.

He became the first victim of her back-smacking assault.

"M-Ma'am, please calm down…"

"Move! Are you going to move or not?!"

Smack! Smack!

"Urgh! Gah!"

"Jin Taekyuuung!"

Then a kick from a fearless soon-to-be college freshman, freshly liberated from the college entrance exam, struck him squarely between the legs.

It was an unfortunate accident.

Wham!

"…Oh."

"…Ah."

Team Leader Choi, his eyes wide, muttered in a hollow voice.

“M-My special underwear… It doesn’t burn, it doesn’t get wet, and it even has a semipermanent cleaning spell…”

Goodbye, Team Leader Choi.

You should’ve enchanted it with reinforcement instead.

Thump. Thud.

I paid my respects to the modern-day knight-errant brought to his knees by pain, then resolutely prepared for the storm coming my way.

Open Inventory. Equip Fire Dragon Armor.

I felt the armor of the divine weapon gently envelop my chest, stomach, and back beneath my hospital gown, and closed my eyes.

At that exact moment, someone’s palm slammed into my cheek.

Smack!

Wait. A slap in the face wasn’t part of my calculations…

I regained consciousness after a week.

No, it was announced that I had regained consciousness.

After another week of complicated medical examinations and various loose ends, I held a brief press conference before a sea of microphones and cheering people.

“Mr. Jin, we have screened out the reporters most likely to cause trouble. Simply call on the reporters selected in advance and answer their questions.”

But contrary to Chairman Xiao’s assurances before the press conference, a few reporters hungry for a sweet scoop swarmed in like bees.

“Mr. Jin! We’ve heard that you and Wu Heixing, one of the casualties of this battle, were on bad terms. Is that true?”

The security guards moved to drag the foreign reporter away, but I stopped them with a gesture.

“I already told the investigators everything, but I’ll say it again. It’s all true.”

Flash! Flash!

Flashes several times brighter erupted, along with a burst of murmuring. A Chinese reporter’s lips twitched with a malicious smile as he asked another question.

“Why? What was the reason?”

“The little bastard was rude from the moment we met.”

“What exactly did he…?”

“He called me a peninsula bangzi[2032] and cursed me out. So I called him a chink bastard, and he tried to attack me after the meeting ended.”

[2032] *Bangzi* is a derogatory Chinese term for Koreans.

The smile vanished from the Chinese reporter's face.

"A chink? That's a slur against Chinese people!"

"Oh. Is it?"

I gave a vague nod, then gestured to the security guards.

"Get that chink bastard out of here."

"Let go of me! This is suppression of the press!"

"Suppress that bastard's mouth while you're at it. I'll talk to Chinese people, but I don't talk to chinks. He's exactly like that Wu Heixing bastard."

Right then, someone among the mass of reporters raised a hand and asked a question. This one was Chinese as well.

"Then did you continue to clash with Wu Heixing afterward?"

"I wouldn't call it a clash. I beat him to a jajinmori rhythm[2033] with the spirit of Korea behind every blow, and he quieted down. We got along well enough after that."

"Then…"

"Yes."

I continued solemnly.

"Wu Heixing was killed by the Arch Lich. There was nothing I could do, and I survived thanks to the top-grade potion he left behind. Once again, I offer my condolences for his death."

There. Condolences.

I had to say what needed saying and patch up what needed patching. No matter what crimes Wu Heixing had committed while he was alive or how rotten his character had been, admitting that I'd killed him would only hurt me down the road.

Besides, hardly anyone would believe that Lee Jungryong had lured Wu Heixing into conspiring with him.

People tended to turn away from inconvenient truths.

I imagined the disappearance of a hundred-terabyte USB containing all the treasures of humanity, and tears welled in my eyes.

"And… above all, I feel profound sorrow over the death of Hunter Lee Jungryong, a hero of the Great Cataclysm and the great Senior I respected more than anyone. He was truly a good man."

"Ah…"

The press-conference hall instantly grew solemn. I wiped away the tears rolling down my cheeks and delivered the line I had prepared.

[2033] Jajinmori is a fast rhythmic pattern used in traditional Korean music.

“Although our time together was brief, I will never forget him for as long as I live. I offer my condolences to everyone who died in this war. I’m sorry I couldn’t save even one more person.”

One sentence that brought the wave of criticism to an end.

Considering the gravity of the matter, the press conference was absurdly brief, lasting only around thirty minutes. It was broadcast worldwide by terrestrial and cable networks in numerous countries, as well as through an iTube livestream, drawing a combined live audience of three billion viewers.

Before I could even begin to feel the impact, I went to find someone.

Chapter 429

"Should we head there right away?"

As soon as the press conference ended, the acting Head of Security—no, Xiao Shen—came over and asked. I nodded.

"Let's do that. You know where he is, right?"

"Yes, I do. Then let's go."

Dozens of security officers led by Xiao Shen formed a circle around me and slowly began moving.

Chaos erupted around us at once. Reporters from various networks came swarming over with cameras and microphones in hand.

"Mr. Jin! Is it true that you're close to His Highness Prince Felix?"

"Jin-san! Jin-san!"[2034]

You're the real jinsang here, asshole.

The reporters from various countries hadn't been satisfied with the press conference and latched onto me, but they couldn't break through the Hunter security detail.

Though, of course, one man did manage to push close enough to keep shoving a microphone in my face.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung! We're both Korean, so please, just one interview…"

There was always someone like this wherever you went.

"Oh, sure. Since we're both Korean, please move aside."

I gave him a halfhearted answer and was about to walk past when his familiar face made me stop. I held Xiao Shen back as he moved to block the reporter.

"Wait. Are you with Daspatch?"

"…!"

"I thought so. You published an article about me, didn't you?"

"N-No, I didn't."

That confirms it. You son of a bitch.

I'd been wondering where I'd seen him before. He was the reporter who had posted an article about me having been single my entire life and called it an exclusive.

Ever since then, whenever I searched my name on a web portal, "Jin Taekyung single since birth" appeared as a related search.

"Shen."

Xiao Shen, who had been standing there bewildered because he couldn't understand our conversation in Korean, bowed his head.

[2034] The Japanese address *Jin-san* sounds like the Korean word *jinsang*, meaning an obnoxious nuisance.

"Yes, hyung."[2035]

"Crack down on him."

"Yes, sir."

Xiao Shen answered energetically and grabbed the Daspatch reporter by the wrist.

"Sir, I will enforce balance."

"W-Wait!"

It was already too late. The reporter went airborne under Xiao Shen's tremendous strength and dropped into the crowd. Several cameras shattered, and curses in languages from around the world poured down like hail.

I exclaimed in admiration at the feast of profanity spanning five oceans and six continents.

"So this is the global village."

"Huh?"

"Nothing. Let's keep going."

The public-security officers who had been waiting nearby rushed over to join us, clearing a path.

Under the crowd's watchful eyes and the protection of an impenetrable escort, I headed for my destination.

A short while later, I met him in a suite at the five-star hotel where the VVIPs were staying.

"Johnson."

"Oh, Jin. You're earlier than I expected."

Magic Johnson had been studying something with a grave expression, but he rose from his seat with a bright smile.

He clapped a thick hand on my shoulder, guided me to a seat, and asked, "So, did the press conference go well?"

Judging by the question, he probably hadn't watched the press conference himself.

I accepted the canned beer Johnson handed me and answered,

"It was all right. I gave them some reasonable answers and wrapped it up in thirty minutes."

"Ha-ha. I doubt the reporters were very happy."

"They probably like me a lot more than they like you. At least I held a press conference."

As soon as the war ended, Magic Johnson had shut himself away in his accommodations and refused to show himself.

Unlike Faye Chen or Prince Felix, the other S-rank Hunters, he hadn't appeared anywhere. Some people had even begun spreading rumors that he was dead.

[2035] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses to address an older man with whom he is close.

Only after things reached that point did he post a brief comment on his official social-media account. That was the full extent of his public activity.

> I am researching something new.
> It is as mysterious and magnificent as the victory we achieved this time.

Most people had probably nodded and moved on without understanding what he meant, but I was one of the few who knew what that “something new” was.

“So? How did it turn out?”

The corners of Magic Johnson’s mouth twitched.

“Who knows?”

“Oh, so it was a success.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You’re doing a terrible job of hiding that you’re holding back a laugh.”

“I’m not. Not at all.”

Yeah, right.

His eyes were shining with anticipation. I let out a quiet laugh.

“I heard you weren’t happy about it at first.”

“You didn’t come to see me then. Did Choi tell you that?”

“Who else could have told me? At the moment, this secret is known by only three people: me, Johnson, and Team Leader Choi.”

“Ah. But Choi got one thing wrong.”

“What?”

“I didn’t refuse at first.”

Magic Johnson drained his five-hundred-milliliter[2036] can of beer in one gulp, then continued gravely.

“I was about to fire off a spell.”

“Ah.”

“I’m not joking. Put yourself in my position. You probably would’ve blown the whole suite apart.”

“If it had been me, I would’ve demolished the hotel.”

The only reason the suite—and the hotel—remained intact was that Magic Johnson was a Grand Mage.

Humans were said to be creatures of curiosity, but mages were curiosity incarnate. That went without saying for a Grand Mage who stood at the pinnacle of magic.

And when presented with an offer involving a “new thing” he had never seen before, he readily accepted it.

[2036] Five hundred milliliters is about 16.9 US fl oz.

“Even after Choi explained everything and I saw it with my own eyes, I couldn’t believe it. This is truly…”

Magic Johnson murmured with a dreamy look in his eyes, then suddenly shook his head.

“No. This won’t do. Come and see for yourself.”

“Good. I nearly died of old age waiting.”

I set down my half-empty beer and rose. Without hesitation, I crossed the spacious suite and stopped in front of one particular spot.

“It’s here, right?”

Magic Johnson nodded. It wasn’t particularly surprising that an S-rank Hunter sensitive to the flow of energy could sense that something was off.

“That’s right. You really know your stuff.”

“Even someone fairly observant would have a hard time noticing this.”

To the naked eye, it looked like an ordinary section of the room.

But I had known from the moment I stepped into the suite.

It was magic that blocked every sound and sight.

“Wait a moment. I’ll dispel the magic right aw—”

Whoosh! Slash!

Magic Johnson’s eyes widened before he could finish speaking.

The edge of my hand, wrapped in Force, swept down through empty air, and the various spells he had laid out split apart cleanly.

“Jin. What on earth…?”

During my battle with the Arch Lich, I had opened my Middle Dantian and gained the ability to see the texture of qi.

That had made things like this possible, but I offered no explanation. I simply stared straight ahead.

As the magic was dispelled, a single layer peeled away from the space before me.

Beyond it stood a man.

“Ah, eh, ee, oh, oo. Hellow. Nishe to meet you. I like rice-soup freaks. I wuv kimchi.”

The blond foreigner had been standing in front of a full-length mirror, holding something as he practiced Korean with awkward pronunciation. He spotted my reflection and turned around.

A hint of laughter crossed his pretty-boy face.

“At last, you have arrived, vile human.”

Look at this bastard pronouncing only that perfectly.

For a moment, I considered hitting him. Instead, I let out a quiet laugh.

“You’ve gotten better-looking since I last saw you.”

The blond foreigner—the Skeleton King—replied smugly.

"You have become even uglier since I last saw you."

"…"

"Ugly as hell."

"…No, you son of a bitch."

Where the hell had this bastard learned Korean?

"Hmm. Beautiful, as expected. Nothing about him looks out of place."

Magic Johnson kept smiling in satisfaction like a plastic surgeon in Gangnam.[2037]

"Even after seeing him again, I have to say he's an unprecedented masterpiece. I may be the first mage in human history to carve a Magic Formation into a Skeleton's bones—and not merely a Skeleton, but an entirely new Named Monster."

This wasn't just a surgeon praising his own handiwork. It was true.

Glossy blond hair. Mysteriously gleaming golden eyes. A well-balanced build nearly 190 centimeters[2038] tall, with long limbs bearing just the right amount of body hair.

And that wasn't all.

His muscles and veins stood out clearly, and his body responded naturally whenever he breathed or swallowed.

Even I had to study him closely to notice anything unusual. The Skeleton King looked completely human.

"…Wow. It actually worked."

I'd made the request thinking I had nothing to lose, but I hadn't expected the result to be this perfect.

I swallowed hard in amazement and reached out to touch his blond hair.

That was when—

Swish.

The Skeleton King took one step back and looked at me arrogantly.

"Take your filthy hand away. You will damage my hair."

"…"

"Will you take responsibility if I go bald?"

This bastard really is human now…

I was too dumbfounded to speak.

[2037] Gangnam is a district of Seoul known for its concentration of cosmetic-surgery clinics.

[2038] 190 centimeters is about 6 ft 3 in.

Ignoring me, the Skeleton King admired his reflection in the full-length mirror and smiled in satisfaction.

“Hmm. Insanely handsome.”

“I’ve been wondering this for a while. Where did you learn expressions like that?”

“On the Internet.”

“The Internet?”

“Indeed. I spent a whole week browsing the shit out of it.”

“Wait. Do you have a phone, too?”

“That kind human over there bought me one. Thank you, Johnson.”

Magic Johnson, who was using a translation spell, nodded with a pleased smile.

“I wish you every success in your new beginning, Mr. King.”

“Thank you, Johnson.”

Thank you, Johnson, my ass. When did he learn basic English, too?

I immediately rounded on Magic Johnson.

“Wait. You even bought him a phone?”

“Hey, Jin. What’s the problem? My youngest daughter is five, and even she uses a smartphone.”

“That’s your youngest daughter. He’s the Skeleton King.”

“Hold on, vile human. I apologize for interrupting your conversation, but this must be said.”

The Skeleton King cut in with a grave expression.

“From now on, you will call me Stone-King.”

“What is this, another thing that’ll get you pelted with stones?”

“It is my new name. Stone King. Born in Atlanta, Georgia, United States…”

I muttered as I felt a headache coming on.

“Should I just kill him? I’m seriously about to.”

“Would you kill a citizen of the United States?”

“Who’s an American citizen, you lunatic?”

“Perhaps not right now, but I can soon obtain United States citizenship.”

“You should write a web novel for KakaoPage[2039] instead. What kind of idiot comes up with that bullshit?”

Magic Johnson shyly raised one hand.

“Jin, with my connections, it should be entirely poss—”

“Ah! Aah! Aaaaah!”

This was driving me insane.

I clutched my throbbing forehead and turned to Magic Johnson.

“Johnson.”

[2039] KakaoPage is a Korean digital platform that publishes web fiction.

"Hmm?"

"What I asked through Team Leader Choi was for you to make him look human. That was all."

"Of course. That was your request. But I heard our friend here desperately wanted this."

All of this had begun shortly after I first regained consciousness, at the Skeleton King's insistence.

He had loudly complained about how long he was expected to remain trapped inside the cramped Inventory.

His position was that he deserved an appropriate reward in light of his major contributions during the battle. From Team Leader Choi's perspective and mine, that was a perfectly reasonable demand.

He protected Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen during the battle with Lei Fei, and we managed to defeat the Arch Lich thanks to him.

I had already been thinking about how to repay the Skeleton King.

Besides, giving him human form would make many things easier.

He would no longer need to hide, and he could sign a contract with the Peace Guild so that both sides could benefit.

But…

"For starters, this isn't the East Asian appearance I asked for. There may be a lot more foreigners in Korea these days, but he'll still stand out. Especially looking like this."

Before Magic Johnson could answer, the Skeleton King cut in stiffly.

"I asked him to change it."

"What? Why?"

"I saw it on the Internet. Handsome white men do well everywhere in the world."

"…And what exactly are you planning to do with that?"

"I wish to date."

"Oh, God."

Magic Johnson patted my shoulder as I groaned.

"It's all right, Jin."

"What do you mean, it's all right? Do you have any idea how terrifying social media is these days? What if netizens dig up his identity and discover that he wasn't born in Atlanta, Georgia, United States, but is actually a native of the Demon Realm? Does that make any sense? Why did you agree to a request like that?"

"I wanted to try making a face that suited my tastes."

"What?"

"That face is my ideal type."

Oh, for fuck's sake…

I was still at a loss for words when the final blow snapped what remained of my patience.

"Do you feel wronged? Ugly as hell."

"You son of a bitch!"

Crack!

I launched myself forward and drove my fist into the crown of his head.

The Skeleton King let out a strangled groan. He may have bitten his tongue, because bright red blood spurted from the corner of his mouth.

Red blood? Is that part of the illusion magic too? He really did an incredible job recreating—

No, that wasn't the point.

"Die! Die!"

"Ghk! Guhk!"

The moment two burly men started rolling around, the suite became a disaster zone.

A desk caught in the chaos collapsed with a splintering crack, and the stack of documents Magic Johnson had been examining came cascading down over my face.

"W-Wait! Vile human! I cannot see!"

"I'm going to teach you some manners today…!"

Then, in the next instant, I froze.

Among the sheets of paper obscuring my vision, I saw a set of strange yet familiar symbols.

This is…

I left the Skeleton King where he was and rose from my seat, dazedly picking up a sheet of paper printed with the symbols.

Sichuan.

There was no mistake.

It was the exact pattern I had seen in Sichuan—not the modern Chinese province, but Sichuan in Murim.

Chapter 430

My eyelids began to tremble before I even realized it.

Why is this here…?

I remembered it clearly.

Immediately after the Sichuan Blood Tragedy—after the Western Heaven Demon Lord had nearly killed me several times—I had followed the Sect Leaders of the Qingcheng and Emei Sects to a cave in an unnamed cliff.

The space hidden behind the Mystic Gate Formation had been vast, with an enormous formation carved into its center.

The same formation filled with strange patterns and symbols that was now printed in color on the paper in my hand.

But… could the thing the Sect Leaders of Qingcheng and Emei had named the Moving Formation even be called a formation anymore?

I hurriedly thrust the paper toward Magic Johnson.

“Johnson. This—what is this?”

“Huh? What?”

“Why is this here…? No, where the hell did you get it?”

Taken aback by my sudden reaction, Magic Johnson answered with a bewildered expression.

“It’s a magic circle discovered in the city the Arch Lich used as its base.”

“A magic circle?”

“Yes, a magic circle. I was already in the middle of researching it… What’s wrong, Jin? Have you seen it somewhere before?”

“Are there more?”

“Of course. Every sheet of paper I was looking at before you came in is related to it.”

“What?”

Then everything piled on the desk had been related to it?

I looked at the dozens of sheets of paper scattered across the floor.

“Excuse me for a moment.”

“Jin? Jin?”

“Has he finally gone mad? How tragic, you vile and ugly human.”

I ignored Magic Johnson’s flustered calls and the Skeleton King’s nonsense.

My lips pressed firmly together, I rapidly skimmed through the stack of printouts.

Each sheet bore a different set of patterns and symbols. By the time I had examined them all, I had realized one thing.

This is…

There was no mistake. The strange patterns and symbols were identical to the ones I had seen in Murim, only arranged and oriented differently.

And if I assembled all these sheets like pieces of a puzzle, they would form one enormous magic circle.

What the hell is going on?

I felt as though someone had smashed me in the back of the head with a sledgehammer.

I stared silently at the papers for a long time before finally speaking.

“You said this was discovered at the Arch Lich’s base, right?”

Magic Johnson had a cigar between his lips by then. He blew out a cloud of smoke before answering.

“That’s right. I didn’t know anything like this existed at first, but apparently it was discovered shortly after the investigation team went in. The coalition forces sent it to me on the second day.”

“They sent it to you?”

“They wanted my opinion. They couldn’t figure out exactly what the magic circle did, either. They probably contacted the other two as well.”

The other two were probably the Grand Mages besides Magic Johnson. They were the greatest mages alive and true experts in the field.

Which meant this magic circle was something entirely new—something that had never been seen before.

“So, has your research turned up anything?”

“Nothing conclusive yet, but I have a general idea of the magic circle’s purpose.”

“Its purpose?”

“Yes. Fortunately, I have a friend who knows quite a bit about that sort of thing.”

I was just about to ask who he meant when an arrogant voice cut in.

“That would be this very body. The universe’s most insanely handsome man, born in Atlanta, Georgia, United States. Known as Stone-King.”

Right. How had I forgotten about this bastard?

He was a native of the Demon Realm and a Named Monster to boot, so he was bound to know something.

I pressed the Skeleton King for answers as he continued spouting nonsense.

“Cut the bullshit and tell me what you know.”

“Call me Mr. King from now on, and I shall consider it.”

“Mr. King, my ass. You kumquat-looking bastard.”

“Fucking Korean.”

“You son of a bitch.”

“Whoa, whoa!”

When I raised my hand, the Skeleton King instinctively scurried backward and shouted in alarm.

"All right! I said all right!"

"Talk, asshole."

The Skeleton King regarded me warily before speaking.

"It appears to be a magic circle for absorbing life force."

"Absorbing life force?"

"Indeed. It seems the Arch Lich used it to absorb other humans' energy and amass power. With all that magical power at its disposal, it could control countless legions of monsters and open Gates."

China was a vast continent.

Even after suffering staggering casualties during the Great Cataclysm, it was still home to one-fifth of the world's population.

And approximately eighty million people lived in Sichuan Province alone—according to the official statistics, at least.

The monster wave had caused millions of casualties. Add those who had yet to be officially counted, and the number would rise to truly staggering proportions.

And a great many of them must have been sacrificed to provide magical power. Considering the scale of what that bastard did, it all adds up.

I bit down hard on my lip and asked the Skeleton King again.

"Are you sure?"

"It is merely my personal inference. I cannot guarantee it."

"Why not?"

The Skeleton King clicked his tongue.

"Vile human. Can you determine the meaning of magic circles used by other humans simply by looking at them?"

"That's…"

"Of course you cannot. This body is no different. I can raise and command soldiers according to the abilities granted to me, but I cannot wield dark magic like this."

Damn it. He was completely right.

Just as Hunters and monsters were classified according to their respective traits, the Skeleton King only possessed the abilities specific to him.

His answer wasn't what I had hoped for, and I could feel the strength draining out of me. But one important question remained.

"Then how did you guess that it was a life-force absorption magic circle? Can only monsters recognize patterns and symbols like these?"

If the Skeleton King understood these strange patterns and symbols—if he could teach me what they meant—I might finally be able to identify the formation I had seen in Murim.

I looked at him expectantly, only for his answer to dash my hopes a moment later.

"I do not know what those things mean. I could guess what the magic circle was for only because I'm undead."

The Skeleton King pointed at Magic Johnson and continued.

"When I first saw it on paper, I could not tell what it was. But when I visited the site with that human I'm grateful to, I sensed it clearly. The stench of countless deaths hung over the place—more deaths than even I could begin to estimate. That was when I realized what it was."

"Oh…"

I could not hide my disappointment.

If neither Magic Johnson, a Grand Mage, nor the Skeleton King, a Named Monster, could understand them, then deciphering those patterns and symbols anytime soon would be practically impossible.

Damn it.

What the hell was going on?

The formation carved into the center of the cave. The patterns and symbols that had appeared in the magic circle discovered this time. The bizarre phenomena I had witnessed during my battle with the Blood Lord and the Western Heaven Demon Lord…

I desperately tried to deny the ominous thought that flashed through my mind.

That can't be. It's impossible.

Was this a coincidence? Or was it fate?

And if it was fate, what did this connection that had appeared out of nowhere mean?

After pacing silently around the suite for a long time, I abruptly spoke.

"I need to see it for myself."

"Huh?"

"Hmm?"

"Johnson. I can visit the site that bastard went to, right?"

Magic Johnson thought for a moment, then nodded.

"It's classified, but you should be able to get in, Jin. However, only the two of us can be seen. We'll have to carry our friend in an extradimensional pocket, just like last time."

"That's fine. Let's leave right away."

"All right, let's do that. You seem to know something too, Jin."

Just as Magic Johnson and I were about to leave, the Skeleton King cut in with a dignified voice.

"I apologize for interrupting, humans, but this body has pressing business. You two may go without me."

"…?"

"…?"

"The woman at the hotel's front desk is exceptionally beautiful. Though concealed beneath human skin, the curves of the skeleton within are exquisite."

I quietly asked,

"So?"

"What do you mean, 'so'? I am informing you that I shall be spending the night out. Now, I must go arrange a date with the beauty… But, vile human."

"What?"

"May I ask why you suddenly took out a spear?"

"Ah, this?"

I casually waved White Flame, which I had somehow already drawn from my Inventory.

"It's nothing. I was going to stab you when you turned around."

"I see."

"Exactly."

"…"

"Why aren't you leaving? The employees will be getting off work soon. You should hurry over and ask her to dinner."

The Skeleton King hesitated, an awkward smile tugging at his lips.

"Now that I think about it, I suppose I can take my time trying to win her over."

"Wow, then you've got some free time. In that case…"

I smiled brightly and pulled out one of the extradimensional pockets I had acquired to conceal the existence of my Inventory from other people.

"Get in, asshole."

"…Okay."

The Skeleton King answered dejectedly and slipped inside the extradimensional pocket.

The moment I saw the magic circle with my own eyes, I understood what the Skeleton King had meant.

Or perhaps it only seemed that way because I had heard his explanation immediately beforehand.

Either way, the sight overwhelmed me, and a single word rose unbidden to my mind.

Death.

The enormous dark magic circle dwarfed the one I had seen in the cave.

Although its magical power had been cut off and it had lost its original function, even the traces of death left behind by the countless lives it had once claimed had not disappeared.

And… that was all I could sense.

“Jin. What do you think? Do you have any idea what it is?”

“No. None at all.”

The patterns and symbols, arranged in an incomprehensible order, remained impossible to decipher.

Just as it had in Murim, the System remained silent. After wandering around the site for hours without learning anything, I had no choice but to turn back.

“Mr. Johnson, Jin. We’ve prepared an escort to ensure you encounter no inconvenience on your way back…”

“We’re fine.”

“Yes, sir. Then I hope we meet again.”

We left the head of security and his guards behind after they snapped off razor-sharp salutes.

Once he had made sure no one was nearby, Magic Johnson quietly moved his lips.

“Jin. You knew something, didn’t you?”

“…A dream. I think I saw something similar in a dream.”

“Hmm.”

“Johnson. Can I look around by myself for a while?”

“Of course. How long do you think you’ll be?”

“I’ll be back soon.”

I began walking slowly through the ruins.

Although it was well past midnight, the city was as bright as noon, and countless people and machines were working to clear the wreckage.

The same work was probably underway in every city caught up in the war.

It must be the same in Sichuan.

China’s Sichuan and Murim’s Sichuan belonged to entirely different worlds. Murim was not the modern world’s past, nor was the modern world Murim’s future.

But now a connection had appeared between those utterly different worlds—and it was not the first.

The capsule.

Everything surrounding me had begun with the junk capsule I had picked up at a recycling center.

How? Why? For what reason?

More questions crowded my mind with every step, leaving my thoughts in complete disarray.

"Phew."

At my deep sigh, the Skeleton King—whom I had quietly moved from the extradimensional pocket into my Inventory—asked,

"Are you all right, vile human?"

"Are you worried about me now?"

"No. If you are all right, let us hurry back to the hotel. Johnson told me a few days ago that there is a club nearby with a great crowd."

"…"

Give me back my touching moment, you lunatic.

I considered telling him that the club Johnson had mentioned was a gay bar, but held my tongue.

"Forget it. What did I expect from you?"

"So, when are we going back?"

"I'm going, asshole. I said I'm going!"

At that exact moment—

"Where are you so desperate to go? Hell?"

At the sound of the voice—harder and colder than ever before—I slowly turned around.

Without realizing it, I must have ventured deep into the ruins. Beyond the relatively dark ruins, a familiar figure was making his way through a collapsed building toward me.

"Hell is where your old man went. If I die, I'm going to heaven."

The eyes of Go Jun—Lee Jungryong's Disciple and Head of Security—turned ice-cold.

Chapter 431

“Vile human. Who is that human?”

So there is one. A human with no sense of fear.

I muttered to myself and slowly looked around.

The desolate outskirts were far from the center, abandoned by everyone. Even the light illuminating the city as brightly as day had yet to reach this place.

And from among the ruins, a single person came walking out, casting a shadow.

“We must be bound by fate somehow. We keep running into each other.”

Go Jun answered my greeting in a cold voice.

“Not fate. An ill-fated bond.”

“Then what do you call meeting in a place like this? Coincidence?”

His answer was as sharp as a blade.

“Inevitability.”

“Clear enough. So have you been following me around like a stray dog since earlier?”

“When did you notice?”

“Since the Stone Age, you bastard. You stared at me so much that I thought you were going to bore holes in my face.”

I had sensed someone secretly watching me as soon as I left the Magic Formation site.

It was an unpleasant, clinging gaze, completely different from the curiosity and admiration everyone else directed at me.

And under the current circumstances, very few people would be openly hostile toward me.

“It was either you or those Crown Prince Party Chinese bastards. But they’re too busy cleaning up the shit they left everywhere… So the answer was obvious, wasn’t it?”

The words had clearly hit the mark, but Go Jun showed no surprise whatsoever.

“As expected. So you did notice.”

“As expected?”

“I thought you would. Otherwise, you wouldn’t have left Magic Johnson behind and come all the way out here alone.”

Well, look at this bastard.

Only then did I understand why Go Jun wasn’t surprised. He had deliberately sent me a signal—a signal to follow him.

This wasn’t surveillance or a lure. This was exactly the situation both Go Jun and I had wanted.

Of course, the outcome would be nothing like what he expected.

“There’s something I want to ask.”

Go Jun didn’t wait for an answer. He stared straight at me and continued.

“Was it you?”

It was a short, simple question, but the meaning behind it was unmistakable. I tilted my head and innocently asked,

“What was?”

“You know.”

“You don’t actually think I killed Uncle Jungryong, do you?”

The moment he heard Lee Jungryong’s name, Go Jun’s eyes shook violently. Without waiting for his answer, I covered my mouth with both hands.

“My God. How could you think something so horrible? Are you serious?”

“Enough of that disgusting act. Do you think I’m asking because I don’t know?”

“Then why ask? Didn’t you watch the press conference?”

“I did. You spouted nothing but lies and bullshit from beginning to end.”

Drip. Drip.

Drops of blood fell from the fist he had clenched so tightly that it had turned white. Go Jun glared at me with eyes burning with rage.

“There are only two people here—you and me. Tell me the truth with your own lips.”

“Vile human! How dare you leave out this Atlanta-born Stone King!”

That made one more monster present.

More precisely, there were two people and one monster. Though I wasn’t sure whether the Skeleton King could still be called a monster.

“Hmm.”

I scratched the back of my head as I studied Go Jun, then said,

“That’s right. I killed him.”

“…!”

“Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing. I took care of both of them. Those lunatics had cooked up a ridiculous scenario. They planned to kill me without laying a finger on the Arch Lich. And the result… Well, you know how that turned out.”

Suspecting the truth and hearing it confirmed were two entirely different things.

Even if he had already guessed what happened, hearing the answer directly from his enemy’s mouth was another matter altogether.

I drove the final nail into the coffin for Go Jun, whose body was trembling violently.

“What else was I supposed to do with bastards like that? I bought them both tickets to the United States. Uncle Jungryong even got first class.”

“You… You dared do that to him…!”

Whoosh!

Killing intent erupted from Go Jun’s entire body, freezing the air around us.

I stared at the fingers twitching toward his sword hilt, then spoke abruptly.

“What are you doing?”

“…!”

Go Jun’s eyes flew wide open. At the same time, the killing intent swirling around us vanished without a trace.

No—it had been crushed beneath the wave of qi pouring from me.

The balance of power shifted in an instant, and I slowly stepped forward.

“You’ve improved by leaps and bounds since the last time I saw you. If you think about it, you’re far better than Wu Heixing. Just what I’d expect from the Disciple Lee Jungryong trained at his side.”

Step.

“But…”

Step.

With each step I took, Go Jun’s face grew paler.

The gap between our powers was overwhelming. A rabbit could not defeat a tiger. The moment he made even the slightest movement to draw his sword, my teeth would sink into his neck.

“You should check where you’re lying down before you stretch out your legs. Why would you settle into your own grave?”

Bang!

Compressed air exploded from the tip of the finger I had raised leisurely.

With a sharp crack, a stream of Finger Qi shot toward Go Jun, who stood frozen like a stone statue. Then—

Clang!

It sent the sword strapped to his waist flying far into the distance.

Go Jun’s rigid expression twisted, his eyes still wide. I let out a short laugh.

“What? Did you think I was going to kill you?”

“…Why?”

“If you want to die that badly, be more discreet next time—and come prepared to actually die. Don’t set some half-assed trap like you did today.”

My hand shot out like lightning. Go Jun had no time to react.

Bang!

The three streams of Finger Qi I fired pierced somewhere beyond the thick darkness. A moment later—

Thud-thud-thud!

Three unconscious figures in black dropped out of thin air in the distance.

They were all high-level Hunters trained in stealth and concealed by various kinds of magic, but none of them could escape my Qi Sense, which had grown even sharper after the opening of my Middle Dantian.

“What, were you filming me on the sly? You fucking hidden-camera creep.”

Tap. Tap.

Clicking my tongue, I tapped Go Jun on the cheek. A voice full of spite slipped between his clenched teeth.

“Do you think you people will get away with this?”

“You people?”

“We—the Ares Guild—will not fall. We will definitely avenge that person’s death…”

Smack!

A tooth flew out in a spray of blood. I seized Go Jun by the collar and slapped him again.

Smack!

Once more.

Smack!

And again.

Smack!

Inner-Family Heavy Hand.

Instead of tearing through his bones and flesh, the internal energy carried in my palm burrowed into Go Jun and rattled his brain.

He staggered like a drunk, unable to keep his balance. I grabbed him by the throat.

“Remember what I’m about to say. Remember it clearly.”

“Ghk…!”

A bloody foam burst out with his groan and splattered across my face. An unfamiliar man was reflected in his unfocused eyes, his expression numb as he continued speaking.

“You started this, but I’ll be the one to finish it.”

In the end, the modern world was also ruled by the logic of power.

Hunters possessed superhuman abilities, while others wielded equivalent authority. They made rules to suit themselves and broke them whenever they pleased. No matter what they did, no one ever showed them a yellow card or a red card.

When Lee Jungryong cut off Uncle Kkeokjeong’s arm to keep him in check, people like them had considered it only natural.

But—

“You shouldn’t have done that.”

A new referee had stepped onto the field, so the rules had to change.

And the new rules were very simple.

I pressed Go Jun's Mute Acupoint and muttered,

"An eye for an eye. A tooth for a tooth."

I twisted both his arms and pulled with all my strength, as though wringing out laundry.

Crack-crack-crack!

With a sickening tear of flesh, both arms came free from his body.

An enormous amount of blood poured out, and the whites of his bulging eyes showed. A silent scream spilled from his mouth, its Mute Acupoint sealed.

"It's not over yet."

I shoved my fingers into the ragged stumps of his arms. The Scorching Yang Qi in my hand seared his flesh, inflicting even greater pain. I pinned down his writhing body and grabbed him by the ankles.

"This won't be enough for someone like you."

Crack!

My Strength could reduce even a thousand-geun[2040] boulder to powder. The bones in both his legs shattered at once, breaking into hundreds of fragments.

"…!"

His body thrashed soundlessly.

As Go Jun lost consciousness from the unimaginable pain, I poured internal energy into him.

Once the light returned to his fading eyes, I hammered my fist into his shattered legs.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

By the time I finally stopped punching, what lay sprawled across the ground was no longer a human being but a large lump of meat.

The faint breath leaking from his nose and mouth was the only proof that he remained alive.

The Skeleton King, who had watched everything from inside my Inventory, spoke in a trembling voice.

"Human."

I answered dryly.

"What?"

"N-No. It's just…"

His voice trailed off, but I already knew what he wanted to say.

"Yeah. It's cruel."

"…"

[2040] A thousand Korean geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

"But it was necessary."

The helplessness of being unable to do anything. Pain so unbearable that death seemed a hundred—even a thousand—times preferable.

And the fear that I could do the same thing to them anytime I wanted.

I needed to plant all of that in my enemy's heart and carve it into his bones.

Of course, there was another option that would leave the fewest loose ends.

Death.

My fingertips twitched before I realized it.

With just a little more force—only a tiny bit—I could kill Go Jun.

It was the perfect opportunity to eliminate even the slightest possibility.

But…

The timing isn't right.

Doubts surrounding the truth never disappeared completely.

Conspiracy theories claimed that humanity had never landed on the moon, or that countless famous figures recorded as dead were actually still alive. This was no different.

If Lee Jungryong disappeared, followed by Wu Heixing and then Go Jun—and it came to light that I had "coincidentally" been here at exactly the right time—the rumors surrounding me would cease to be mere conspiracy theories.

So this was where I had to stop.

Now, after showing him the overwhelming gap between our powers and planting the fear of me deep inside him.

"I'll say this one last time."

"…!"

Go Jun's body flinched. In a voice lower and more emotionless than ever, I bit out every word.

"Let it end with Lee Jungryong alone."

My breath, hot as lava, brushed against him, and his prone body convulsed.

Like a rabbit feeling a tiger's teeth sink into its neck.

"Hide your teeth. Sheathe your claws. If you do that… nothing will happen."

If he had set out to kill, he should have been prepared to die.

Lee Jungryong had been my greatest enemy and obstacle. In the end, he had paid the price for what he had done.

What I was offering now was a chance to make peace.

No—a demand.

And Go Jun had only one choice left.

His head moved in the faintest nod.

I stared into his eyes, drenched in fear and dread, then pressed his Sleep Acupoint. After taking several high-grade potions from my Inventory, I poured them over his body.

Hissssss.

I watched his wounds rapidly heal, then suddenly turned my head.

“So… that’s more or less what happened.”

At that moment, a layer of space peeled away, revealing a huge Black man. Magic Johnson regarded me with a complicated expression before speaking.

“I think there’s a lot we need to talk about.”

“I was thinking the same thing.”

As we spoke, the Skeleton King muttered quietly.

“What about the club?”

That’s a gay bar, dumbass.

Chapter 432

Magic Johnson was a good man.

Whether on the battlefield or in civilian life, he was always the same.

No matter the situation, he remained cheerful and never lost his smile. He had shown particular kindness to Team Leader Choi and me, even secretly handling the matter of the Skeleton King for us.

But there was no trace of playfulness or laughter in the way Magic Johnson looked at me now.

He stared at me in silence, a jumble of emotions in his eyes, before suddenly speaking.

“How much of it is true?”

“All of it. From beginning to end. Everything you saw and heard.”

I put particular emphasis on the word *everything*. Magic Johnson wasn’t dense enough to miss what I meant.

“…So you knew from the beginning.”

“As you know, I’m pretty sensitive.”

“And you didn’t care?”

“I didn’t expect you to follow me. But then I thought this might not be such a bad thing.”

“I was curious. Part of me was worried, too. It was obvious you knew something about that mysterious pattern, and just as obvious that you were hiding it.”

Before we parted, when Magic Johnson had asked about the Magic Formation, I had made the excuse that I thought I had seen something similar in a dream.

Of course, I hadn’t expected him to believe me. It had been a roundabout way of telling him not to ask about it for now.

“So I followed you, just in case…”

Magic Johnson trailed off and surveyed the blood-soaked surroundings.

“Looks like I shouldn’t have bothered.”

Two S-rank Hunters—each practically the face of his own country—had died in this momentous incident. One of them had even been a comrade who had once fought alongside Magic Johnson on the same battlefield.

Some truths were uncomfortable to know.

For Magic Johnson, this must have been one of them.

“Do you regret it?”

“A little. Maybe I would’ve been better off not knowing.”

Magic Johnson let out a quiet sigh and looked me straight in the eye.

“Jin. Why are you telling me all this?”

"Who knows?"

"You were the only one who knew the truth. If you wanted to, you could have covered it up. The same goes for him."

I glanced at the unconscious Go Jun and shook my head.

"This wasn't something I could hide just by keeping quiet. No matter how much I denied it, that bastard would never have believed me. Lee Jungryong and Go Jun were both ticking time bombs—dangerous enough to threaten my people."

"Jin. You… were their enemy. You have been for a long time."

"Yes. If you can't eliminate an enemy, you have to make them so afraid of you that they'll never dare look your way again. A bomb with its detonator removed can't explode."

"Then what about me? Why did you tell me?"

"You already know. In a situation like this, there are only two kinds of people you can choose."

I continued slowly, enunciating each word.

"Enemies. Or friends."

"…!"

"I thought you would believe me, Johnson. Because you're my friend."

Magic Johnson let out a low groan and stared at me, countless emotions mingling in his eyes.

"Being friends doesn't mean believing everything the other person says, Jin."

"But you believed me. You didn't doubt me once during our entire conversation."

"…"

"Help me. Help me protect my people and build my strength."

For some time now, I had felt everything around me beginning to change.

In Murim, Dark Heaven had begun to stir. In the modern world, the Arch Lich—a Named Monster unlike any that had come before it—had slaughtered millions and brought catastrophe in its wake.

Then there were the mysterious patterns and symbols that had appeared in both worlds.

Or perhaps they were something that could be called *dark magic*.

Could all of this really be a coincidence?

Everything that happened in the world was connected by invisible links. If I didn't want it all to topple like a row of dominoes, I had to prepare.

And to do that, I desperately needed an ally.

"Johnson."

"…Damn it."

Magic Johnson remained silent for a moment before letting out a deep sigh.

"You know something?"

"…?"

"That day—if you hadn't asked me to teleport you straight into the monster army, I might have doubted you."

That one remark was as good as an agreement.

My face lit up, and Magic Johnson couldn't help but laugh.

"Damn it. It's too late to turn back now. First, let's clean this place up before the patrol arrives."

He waved a hand, and the blood splattered everywhere vanished without a trace.

After cleaning the area in an instant with Clean magic, Magic Johnson frowned at Go Jun's fallen body.

"He's the problem… I'd like to erase his memories entirely, but given the circumstances, that would be difficult. What a pain."

"Huh?"

My ears perked up.

I suddenly remembered how the Ares Guild's mages had used memory-manipulation magic on the Myeongdong Guild members who had been present when I stormed their Guild.

"You can do that?"

"It would obviously be difficult, but not impossible. The stronger the target's will and the more extensive the memories that need to be altered, the harder it becomes."

"Oh."

"He seems quite strong. In the worst case, we could fail and leave behind evidence that someone attempted to manipulate his mind."

Go Jun might not look it now, but he was strong enough to qualify as an S-rank Hunter.

Unlike Wu Heixing, he was also fairly strong-willed, so trying it could be a needless gamble.

"Leaving evidence would be a problem."

"Yes. If it were discovered, there'd be no avoiding punishment. Mental-manipulation magic is a serious felony."

Yet Lee Jungryong and the Ares Guild had done such things without the slightest hesitation.

Even if someone noticed, they wouldn't dare question it. Everyone knew how much power and influence they possessed.

"Still, if we tried and succeeded…"

"Under federal law, the minimum sentence would be one hundred years in prison without parole. Want to try?"

I answered without taking a breath.

"No."

"Good boy. Wise decision."

A minimum of one hundred years without parole?

If I got caught, I'd rot in prison without a chance. Even if I escaped, I'd spend the rest of my life as an internationally wanted fugitive.

I might even end up with a ten-billion-beri[2041] bounty on my head, living as a pirate on Somalia's Grand Line like some manga character.

The thought alone was horrifying…

"What a shame. If this were Korea, it might be worth trying."

"Korea? Why?"

"If you spread enough money around and hired a former chief prosecutor who could benefit from *jeongwan yewu*,[2042] you probably wouldn't get much of a sentence."

"Jeongwan yewu?[2043] What's that?"

"It's a thing. Ah, if you said you'd done it while drunk after downing about five bottles of soju,[2044] you might even get a suspended sentence."

Magic Johnson laughed loudly as if he had heard an incredible joke.

"Don't be ridiculous, Jin. What kind of country would allow that?"

"…"

"You're serious? My God."

In any case, memory-manipulation magic was off the table.

Leaving Go Jun where he lay, I walked away. The three A-rank Hunters he had concealed nearby were frozen like statues, their Paralysis Acupoints struck by the Finger Qi I had fired at them.

"You saw everything, right?"

The three men looked up at me with terror-filled eyes.

Sometimes watching someone else suffer inspired even greater fear than experiencing it yourself.

Unable to move so much as a finger, they had watched Go Jun get brutally and thoroughly crushed. They looked half out of their minds.

"I remember all three of your faces. Getting your personal information is only a matter of time."

It was the same method the powerful had always used.

[2041] Beri is the fictional currency in the manga *One Piece*. Its Grand Line is a sea route sailed by pirates.

[2042] *Jeongwan yewu* is the unofficial preferential treatment often afforded to lawyers who formerly served as judges or prosecutors, particularly through their old professional connections.

[2043] *Jeongwan yewu* is the unofficial preferential treatment often afforded to lawyers who formerly served as judges or prosecutors, particularly through their old professional connections.

[2044] Soju is a clear Korean distilled liquor, commonly served in small glasses.

If I couldn't kill them, I had to use that method to instill fear in them. I had to make sure they never dared bare their teeth at me again.

"If we meet like this again… I'll kill you."

Whoosh!

The killing intent that erupted from me sliced through the air and crushed everything around us.

After reining in my qi, I slowly swept my gaze over their corpse-pale faces, then thrust out a hand.

Crack-crack-crack!

"Ghk!"

"Hah, huff…"

Finally released from the Pressure-Point Strike, the men gasped for breath. Tears pooled in their bloodshot eyes, while saliva and vomit streamed from their open mouths.

"I'll give you ten seconds. Take that bastard and get lost."

There was no question who *that bastard* meant.

Before I had even finished speaking, the three men scrambled to their feet and rushed toward Go Jun.

They hoisted their still-unconscious superior onto one man's back and fled with lightning speed.

I called one final warning after them.

"Erase everything that happened today from your memories. And think carefully about which ship you need to board if you want to stay alive."

"…!"

"…!"

"…!"

The Ares Guild was a massive, sturdy ship.

But its great captain, Cheon Taemin, had vanished without a trace long ago. Now Lee Jungryong, the man who had taken the helm after him, had also met his death.

The ship that had once seemed destined to sail the seas forever was beginning to list.

A captain couldn't abandon his ship, but the sailors hired to serve aboard it were different.

If they wanted, they could find a new ship and a new shipowner.

That should be enough for them to understand.

The three men hesitated briefly at my words, then disappeared into the darkness.

They offered no answer or visible reaction, but I knew one thing.

They would never forget what I had said.

They would turn it over in their minds dozens—hundreds—of times before passing it on to their fellow Guild members. Then, little by little, water would begin seeping into the bottom of the enormous ship called the Ares Guild.

"Ooh, wicked human. Oooooh."

"This is what you call strategy, you idiot."

"How can someone so stupid be this underhanded and cunning?!"

"…You son of a bitch."

He wasn't wrong, but it still pissed me the fuck off.

Let's just say that after several years as a Hunter, I had picked up a few things through experience.

Magic Gems were now the essential power source of cutting-edge civilization. Naturally, that drew enormous amounts of capital. Capital attracted people, and wherever people gathered, all kinds of things were bound to happen.

I've put the bait out with what I know… If I wait, someone will bite.

Just as a sect's standing in Murim was determined by the martial artists it possessed, a modern Guild's standing was determined by the caliber of its Hunters.

And Go Jun could never fill the void Lee Jungryong had left behind.

Just as Lee Jungryong had never been able to fill the void left by Cheon Taemin.

It was only a matter of time before the fish spotted another tempting lure beyond that empty space and began swimming away.

"You certainly don't hesitate. Are you planning to go to war with the Ares Guild?"

I shrugged at Magic Johnson's question.

"It's not like I couldn't, but we should keep up appearances."

"Appearances, huh?"

"The Peace Guild is going to grow enormously from now on. It has me, and Team Leader Choi is attracting plenty of media attention too."

"Oh, I heard about that. Apparently Choi's been making quite a name for himself lately."

The global media spotlight was focused on me, but the more I avoided the press, the more attention shifted toward Team Leader Choi.

He belonged to the same Peace Guild as I did and was one of the very few people allowed to visit my hospital room.

On top of that, he had distinguished himself during this monster wave and was handsome enough to put celebrities to shame.

And his greatest secret still hasn't been revealed.

If the truth—that he was Cheon Taemin's own flesh and blood—ever became public, the media would undoubtedly go into a frenzy.

"Anyway, it's only a matter of time before the Peace Guild takes off. Meanwhile, the Ares Guild's influence will shrink by the day."

“Hmm. I can certainly see that happening.”
Magic Johnson nodded, then suddenly spoke.
“But, Jin.”
“Yes?”
“What exactly do you know about the Magic Formation—”
“Oh, right. The club!”
“Huh?”
“You said you were going to a club with the Skeleton King.”
“Wait, wait, Jin!”
“Golgoli! Let’s go to the club!”
“Yes! Raise your ribs and scream!”
Listening to the Skeleton King spout nonsense, I hurried away.
Then, as I gazed up at the faint moonlight, a thought suddenly occurred to me.
I should go back soon.
The time was approaching.
The time to return to another world—to Murim.

Chapter 433

On a state-of-the-art hologram TV, a respectable-looking middle-aged news anchor spoke.

“Twenty days have passed since the monster wave in Sichuan Province—the tragedy dubbed the ‘Small Cataclysm’—finally came to an end. Across the continent, the cries of suffering people fill the air. CCTV correspondent Zhang Weijia is at the scene.”

As soon as he finished speaking, the screen changed.

Amid ruins reduced to rubble and ash, a young reporter in protective gear faced the camera and began to speak.

“Large-scale recovery efforts are currently underway throughout Sichuan Province. Aid continues to arrive from countries around the world, but the scars left by the war are nothing short of horrific.”

The camera slowly panned across the area.

The young reporter dispatched to cover the story was far from the only person there. Countless people of different countries, languages, and nationalities filled the ruins.

“Lift on three! One, two!”

“Hup!”

Thud-thud-thud. Boom!

There were places that heavy machinery could not enter.

Burly Hunters lifted chunks of stone and concrete instead of weapons, while mages cast detection magic without rest in search of possible survivors.

“How does it look?”

“There don’t seem to be any survivors within a hundred-meter radius.[2045] Let’s move a little and try again…”

“Here! We’ve got a survivor reading over here! Hurry!”

Whenever a severely injured survivor was rescued, healers rushed in and showered them with potions and healing magic.

When a child who had reached the brink of death finally drew a steady breath, the people around them exchanged deeply moved smiles.

But the joy lasted only a moment.

The reporter’s next words brought the cruel reality crashing back.

“According to government authorities, the number of dead and injured identified so far has reached four million. Property damage amounts to 2.3 trillion yuan. This is the greatest loss suffered since the Great Cataclysm—dozens of times greater than the damage caused by the Great Sichuan Earthquake.”

[2045] A hundred-meter radius is about 328 ft.

In barely a month, millions had died or been injured, and an astronomical amount of money had vanished.

Even more frightening was the fact that all of this was merely the damage tallied *so far*.

Considering everything from the plunging stock market to the damage this incident had inflicted on various industries, China would suffer badly in the days ahead.

The Chinese people were consumed by grief and fury at the news, directing the arrows of a billion people's anger in a single direction.

The young reporter at the scene was no exception. His voice seethed with indignation as he continued.

"This monster wave was like a natural disaster beyond human power to stop. But if everyone had joined forces to prepare for the disaster and respond swiftly, the situation would have been very different. Chairman Xiao Yang has offered a profound apology and released the transcript of last month's meeting."

Its contents were shocking.

The transcript of the Communist Party's highest committee meeting, previously hidden from the public, laid bare the bitter clash between Chairman Xiao Yang's faction, which had urged them to seek immediate assistance from other countries, and the Crown Prince Party, which had argued that they should rally the power of Zhonghua[2046] and fight with the spirit of chivalry.

One person stood out above all the rest.

The star of the transcript was an old politician who had lost everything following the loss of his only son, Wu Heixing.

"Committee Member Wu Xueming, Premier of the State Council and a member of the Central Politburo Standing Committee, has spent more than fifty years in politics. It has now been revealed that he committed countless acts of corruption while leading the Crown Prince Party, the country's largest political faction."

Had the outcome been favorable, none of this would have happened.

But the power of Zhonghua[2047] and the spirit of chivalry he had gone on about during the meeting at the beginning of the Small Cataclysm had sounded like nothing but bullshit even to those steeped in Zhonghua[2048] ideology. In the end, they had become the laughingstock of the entire world.

Then it came to light that his past corruption involving the military had led to incidents in which tanks broke down and helicopters crashed. Wu Xueming found himself driven to the edge of a cliff.

[2046] Zhonghua refers to China and Chinese civilization; here it invokes Chinese national pride.
[2047] Zhonghua refers to China and Chinese civilization; here it invokes Chinese national pride.
[2048] Zhonghua refers to China and Chinese civilization; here it invokes Chinese national pride.

And Chairman Xiao Yang, a seasoned politician, did not let the perfect opportunity slip by.

"Committee Member Wu Xueming used his guanxi[2049] with prominent figures in the military, political, and business worlds to embezzle astronomical sums of money. We are currently investigating every circumstance connected to this incident."

In truth, the large-scale purge had already begun.

Of the seven standing committee members who formed the Communist Party's highest echelon, the leading figures of the Crown Prince Party—including Wu Xueming—had been summoned one after another. A sweeping reorganization of the military had also taken place.

The media merely pointed its cameras where the government directed and recited whatever the government chose to show.

Several more investigations and trials still lay ahead, but everyone knew they would be nothing more than formalities.

"Comrades of the people, they will pay the price their crimes deserve. That is justice—"

"Hey, mister."

Someone abruptly cut off the young reporter's furious outcry, delivered in complete disregard of his duty as a journalist. His mind went blank.

What kind of lunatic interrupts a live broadcast…?

This was a colossal broadcasting disaster.

The staff at the scene, the main anchor at the broadcasting station's desk, and even the director watching TV in his office all stared openmouthed.

But the man responsible for the entire mess could not have been calmer.

If anything, he sounded annoyed as he addressed the reporter.

"Move aside. It's fine that you're covering the story, but you're getting in the way."

"Pardon?"

"Did someone stuff your ears with stinky tofu?[2050] I'm telling you to go film somewhere else instead of blocking the way in the middle of an active work site."

The young reporter's face turned as white as paper. He stammered and glanced around.

The staff were terrified by the colossal broadcasting disaster unfolding before them, while the nearby Hunters looked as if someone had finally said exactly what they were thinking.

After a brief struggle, the reporter managed to shake off his panic. He forced a smile and addressed the man.

[2049] Guanxi refers to personal relationships and the obligations or influence that come with them.

[2050] Stinky tofu is a fermented tofu dish known for its strong smell.

"I-I'm sorry. It seems we made a mistake."

"To hell with sorry… Ugh, my throat."

Khhk—ptooey.

Covered in dust from head to toe, the man spat out a wad of black phlegm and continued.

"It's only a mistake if you didn't know. I saw you slip the person in charge some money to get in here, so don't give me that."

"E-Excuse me! What exactly are you implying?"

"What do you mean, implying? I saw the whole thing. Wanna bet your balls on it?"

At that moment, the cameraman watching the entire scene unfold at point-blank range felt his own balls tremble.

We're fucked.

His employer, CCTV, was China's largest broadcasting station and one of the five biggest in the world.

And now, during the nine-o'clock evening news broadcast watched by tens of millions of people, someone was proposing a bet involving his balls.

The young reporter was already begging the man with the expression of someone whose balls had been cut off.

"S-Sir, please…"

"Hey, kid. Move while I'm asking nicely."

"This is a broadcast. So please watch your language…"

"Wow, you really don't listen. There's a survivor underneath where you're standing, so move."

"What?!"

The reporter and every member of the staff leaped back as if they had been burned.

Only then did the man nod.

He strode over to a massive pile of concrete and placed a hand on it.

"That's better. Now stay back and don't get in the way. You'll get hurt."

Whoosh! Boom!

There was no need to find anyone to help him.

A chunk of concrete that had taken several Hunters to move flew like a pebble, while rock and ground split apart like cheesecake whenever the man's hand blurred.

Papapapapak!

It was over in the blink of an eye. Before a cup of instant noodles could have finished cooking, the man emerged from the deep pit into which he had vanished.

In his arms was a tiny old woman.

"What… What is this…?"

The broadcasting staff stood speechless at the astonishing sight until the Hunters rushing over pushed them aside.

When a healer in a pure-white robe hurried forward with a potion, the man waved him off.

“Not yet. She’s too weak to handle a potion right now.”

“W-Wait. You look like a close-combat Hunter, but this is my field of expertise…”

“Hmm. I don’t think so.”

The man answered calmly and placed a hand against the old woman’s back.

Warmth radiated from him strongly enough to be felt several meters away,[2051] and a faint trace of color returned to the old woman’s pallid face.

“Move her somewhere warm first. Keep her body temperature up with magic. Once she regains consciousness, you should be able to use a potion or healing magic.”

The healer stared back and forth between the old woman and the man, dumbfounded.

“T-Thank you, sir.”

“No need to thank me for doing the obvious, and no need for the ‘sir.‘ Let’s leave it at that. And… hmm.”

The man hesitated briefly before continuing in a low, subdued voice.

“She’s the last one. In this area.”

“Ah…”

Those who understood what he meant let out low groans.

They included not only the Hunters but the broadcasting staff as well. Strangely, although they accepted his claim, they could not hide their bewilderment.

Why?

All they had to do was glance around to see hundreds of Hunters using magic and cutting-edge equipment to search for survivors. It was only natural to trust them over the man standing before them. They should have dismissed his words as nonsense, and yet…

Somehow, I believe him.

Why?

After the astonishing scene they had just witnessed, all thought of a *broadcasting disaster* vanished from their minds.

Two other thoughts surfaced in its place.

No way. Could it be?

“That’s only my personal opinion. So please don’t give up until the very end.”

[2051] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

The cameraman raised the camera he had unknowingly let droop toward the ground.

Then he called out to the man, who had bowed his head slightly and was about to turn away.

“C-Could you be Mr. Jin?”

His question spoke for everyone present.

The man was so thoroughly covered in dust that they could barely make out his features.

But what he had shown them in that brief moment had clearly reminded them of one person…

“No.”

The answer came without even a breath’s hesitation. The cameraman asked again.

“Y-You’re not?”

“You mean Jin Taekyung? I appreciate the mistake, but why would he be here? According to the news, he hasn’t shown hide nor hair of himself. Who knows what he’s doing?”

That was true. Jin Taekyung was a hero who had not shown his face once since the press conference.

It seemed absurd that they had suspected him based on nothing more than a vague feeling.

Just as the cameraman sighed, the young reporter suddenly spoke.

“Then may I ask you one question?”

“No. Take care.”

“What do you think of the claim that Mr. Jin is descended from Chen Lin, the Ming Dynasty general who fought in the Imjin War?”[2052]

At that moment, the man walking away spun around like lightning.

“Why does everyone have to be someone’s descendant? Then, for fuck’s sake, is Asmodeus descended from Einstein? Even bullshit should make some kind of sense…”

“Ah…”

“Uh…”

A silence fell as if the world itself had stopped.

The man—Jin Taekyung—looked at the people staring blankly at him and opened his mouth.

“You all know I was joking, right?”

“…”

“I was just passing by and stopped in for a moment.”

[2052]The Imjin War was the Japanese invasion of Korea from 1592 to 1598. Chen Lin was a Ming Dynasty general who fought in the war.

"…"

"Please edit this out. And cut the part about the balls too."

The reporter, finally recovering from the shock, barely managed to squeeze out his voice.

"It's live, sir."

"Oh."

Jin Taekyung nodded, his expression devastated, then asked again.

"Live? You're not joking? It's actually live?"

"Yes."

"Then how much of that did you broadcast…?"

"I'm sorry, but from the beginning to the end…"

"Any idea what the ratings are?"

"I just checked the messages. They say we've broken through thirty percent."

"Oh. I see."

Jin Taekyung fell silent for a moment, then started walking away.

The young reporter, whose life had just turned around as a colossal broadcasting disaster transformed into a sensational exclusive, called after him desperately.

"S-Sir! Where are you going?"

The answer came back, drained of all energy.

"Home."

He was telling the truth.

A formation of dozens of aircraft swept across the sky and landed on the vast expanse of freshly cleared ground.

It was the aircraft formation that would take him back to Korea while he was briefly going to another world.

Chapter 434

“Have you looked in a mirror?”

That was the first thing Team Leader Choi, the first person off the aircraft, said to me.

I’d already guessed I looked rough, considering the people around me hadn’t recognized me, but was I really that much of a mess?

“No. Is it bad?”

“Yes. Bad enough that even your family couldn’t recognize you, Mr. Jin.”

“Other people, maybe, but Mom would recognize me. She went through labor to give birth to me.”

“We watched the news together on the flight here. During your interview, she asked who that filthy-looking man was and why he kept snapping at everyone.”

“…Seriously?”

I looked over Team Leader Choi’s shoulder.

Mom poked her head through the open doorway of the private jet and spoke in a voice as tiny as an ant.

“Sorry, son.”

She vanished as soon as she said it, and a slim face appeared in her place. It was Hayeon, her skin glowing as if she’d spent the past several days eating and sleeping to her heart’s content.

“I recognized you right away! I’m the only one who did, right?”

“Who are you? I’m an only child.”

“What the heck?”

Letting Hayeon’s words go in one ear and out the other, I asked Team Leader Choi, “That brat talked the most trash about me, didn’t she?”

“Yes. She was having a wonderful time egging your mother on.”

Yep. She was definitely my sister.

Hayeon must have overheard us, because she immediately pulled her head back inside. She wasn’t just good at studying—she was quick on the uptake, too.

“It’s nice to see such a harmonious family.”

“If we became twice as harmonious, someone would disappear from the family register.”

Team Leader Choi replied with a straight face.

“That would still be better. I don’t have any family. Except for my maternal grandfather, and I don’t even know where he is.”

“…Why are you doing this to me?”

“It was a joke.”

“Please use your turn signal before swerving into my lane like that.”

Team Leader Choi chuckled at my grumbling and extended a hand.

At a brief activation word, an Item imbued with Clean magic flashed brightly.

A cool breeze made of mana swept over me, blowing away all the dust and grime at once.

“Thanks. Much better.”

“Don’t mention it. You’ve certainly kept busy to the very end. You vanished without warning on the day of your departure, which put us in a rather difficult position.”

“You’re making it sound worse than it was. I was planning to be back on time.”

Team Leader Choi stared at me without a word. I scratched the back of my head and continued as if I were making an excuse.

“I just stopped by on the off chance.”

“Mr. Jin.”

“I know what you’re going to say.”

“Even if you do, this still needs to be said.”

Team Leader Choi looked me in the eye and spoke with deliberate clarity.

“You can’t save everyone. Mr. Jin, you… did your best.”

I smiled bitterly.

I had witnessed many deaths, both in the modern world and in Murim.

Sometimes I had been a spectator, far removed from what was happening. Other times, I had been at the heart of it.

And whenever it was all over, I always found myself asking the same question.

Just as I did now.

Was that really the best I could do?

The best.

The greatest and finest one could achieve after devoting every ounce of sincerity and strength.

Those two words frightened me more than anything, because there was no fixed standard for them.

Whether you had done your best was something only you could decide.

But there would always be regrets. Even if they amounted to no more than a few crumbs, as long as they remained buried deep in your heart, you couldn’t truly say you had done your best.

Because doing your best meant having no regrets at all.

“Nice weather today.”

I looked up at the sky and muttered for no particular reason, then grinned at Team Leader Choi.

“Let’s call it second-best. I’ll feel better that way.”

“How you see yourself and how others see you are two different things. To us, it was the best—and more.”

That wasn’t Team Leader Choi’s voice.

I had already sensed his presence, so I turned without surprise.

The owner of the aged voice addressed me with a gentle smile.

“So… you are leaving after all, Mr. Jin.”

I smiled back at Chairman Xiao Yang.

“The hotel rates were higher than I expected.”

“They are merchants, are they not? It is only natural to charge for the services they provide.”

“I might’ve stayed if they’d offered me a discount, but I think they were overcharging me because I’m a foreigner.”

“Oh dear. So that happened. Shall this old man give them a stern talking-to and persuade you to stay a little longer?”

“The bus has already left. It would be rude to chase it down the road and ask the driver to open the door.”

“Then I suppose I have no choice but to let you go. Ha ha.”

As if any hotel would be crazy enough to charge me—let alone overcharge me—in a situation like this.

We traded light jokes while reaffirming each other’s intentions, then clasped hands.

“You have given us more help than I could ever dare measure.”

His voice and gaze were sincere.

The people who had accompanied the Chairman also bowed respectfully to me.

Several familiar faces stood among them, including Xiao Shen and Wei Fenghu, the Minister of National Defense.

I gave them a slight nod and answered with a joke.

“I only did what I had to do. More importantly, it wasn’t volunteer work. You know that, right?”

“Ha ha. Of course.”

I had momentarily forgotten, but the bounty on the Arch Lich’s head had been an astounding fifty trillion won.[2053]

It was such an astronomical sum that even the compensation I’d receive for fighting in a month-long war would look like pocket change beside it.

I had never imagined possessing that much money in my life, and it still didn’t feel real.

[2053] Fifty trillion won is about $36 billion or €32 billion.

Fifty trillion won.[2054]

Only half a year ago, I'd been eating seven-thousand-won[2055] bowls of bone hangover soup to save money, then cooking ramen afterward because one bowl wasn't enough to fill me up.

Maybe that was why I felt more dazed than happy.

"Um, by the way…"

Chairman Xiao Yang raised his eyebrows.

"Are you really going to pay me?"

The instant the words left my mouth, Team Leader Choi firmly stepped on my foot. Chairman Xiao Yang's wrinkled eyes curved into a gentle smile.

"Why? Do you not wish to receive it?"

"No! Of course I do!"

My vehement reply sent a ripple of laughter through the crowd.

Chairman Xiao Yang laughed heartily and patted me on the shoulder.

"Did I not say so? It is only natural to pay a fair price for work performed."

They said China was the Middle Kingdom because it was too large to be a small nation and too narrow-minded to be a Great Nation, but this old man sure was generous.

I scratched my chin awkwardly.

There was nothing wrong with receiving payment under the contract, but accepting a bounty of fifty trillion won[2056] amid such devastation made me feel like a thief rummaging through someone else's storehouse.

"If money's tight, you can pay me in installments."

"If you are worried about rebuilding the damage, that is something our country must handle. Your bounty is being processed quickly, Mr. Jin, so it will be paid officially soon."

Chairman Xiao Yang leaned closer and whispered in my ear.

"When I plowed the fields and pulled out the rotten stalks, piles of gold came tumbling out. So there is no need for you to feel uncomfortable, Mr. Jin."

It took me a moment to realize he was talking about the Crown Prince Party.

According to the news, the assets seized so far already amounted to hundreds of trillions of won.[2057]

And that was before they had even touched Wu Xueming, the faction's de facto leader, or the rest of its leadership.

Now that's some corruption.

[2054] Fifty trillion won is about $36 billion or €32 billion.

[2055] Seven thousand won is about $5 or €4.50.

[2056] Fifty trillion won is about $36 billion or €32 billion.

[2057] Hundreds of trillions of won—roughly 200 to 900 trillion won—would be about $140–640 billion or €130–580 billion.

A country's landmass must be proportional to the size of its people's nerve.

Still, they had ended up penniless and behind bars, so justice had been served to some extent.

Feeling considerably lighter, I answered, "Then I'll accept it gratefully."

"What are you saying? Thanks to you, we were able to prevent an even greater catastrophe. On behalf of all the people who could not be here today, I offer you my thanks once again, Mr. Jin."

Before I could stop them, Chairman Xiao Yang and his attendants bowed respectfully.

The people gathered here were the major officials who moved an entire nation.

They were, in essence, the body and head of China itself.

As I stood there flustered, a familiar voice reached my ear.

"Should I get down on my knees, too?"

"Faye Chen."

She approached with a playful expression and poked me in the cheek.

"You worked hard, young man."

"Not at all. Everyone…"

"Of course everyone worked hard. But if you hadn't defeated the Arch Lich, we wouldn't have this peace. I'm sure everyone feels the same way. Except for that obnoxious prince, of course."

Prince Felix, dressed in a dazzling formal uniform with a snow-white cloak draped over his shoulders, gave an irritated cough and stared at me.

"What?"

"I pay my respects to you, Korean commoner."

"…I appreciate it, but could you leave out the last few words?"

"I pay my respects to you, Korean commoner."

"Are you doing this on purpose?"

"I am sincere."

"I'm sure you are, you bastard. I really am a commoner."

"That is not what I meant."

Prince Felix suddenly extended a hand.

But unlike usual, he didn't offer me the back of his own hand. Instead, he seized mine and pulled it toward him.

Then, while I stood there dumbfounded, he kissed the back of my hand and stepped away.

What the fuck?

Faye Chen burst out laughing at my speechless expression. Prince Felix calmly said what he had to say.

“I have shown you my respect. It shall never happen again, so treasure this honor for generations to come. Until we meet again.”

With that final remark, delivered without the slightest change in expression, Prince Felix swept away with his attendants.

Magic Johnson, who had watched the entire scene, smacked his lips.

“Charming.”

“…That’s your type?”

“Respect my preferences.”

“He has a spouse.”

“That is why I am restraining myself.”

We should never let him visit a Korean convenience store. The moment he took a bite of tuna mayo, the world would be hit by an unprecedented upheaval.

As I shook my head, Team Leader Choi spoke quietly.

“Mr. Jin. It’s time to leave.”

The words weren’t meant only for me, but for everyone gathered there.

I nodded and said my final farewells.

I made sure not to leave out Xiao Shen and Wei Fenghu, with whom I’d spent so much time.

“Take care.”

“We’ll definitely meet again, hyung.”[2058]

Xiao Shen, who was only in his early twenties, rubbed his reddened eyes with his sleeve before continuing.

“I’ll become an outstanding Hunter like you, hyung,[2059] and rise to lead the public security forces that protect everyone.”

“You’re still young, but you’re already blinded by the desire for power. That job must be brutal.”

“I’m ashamed to admit it, but I’ve decided to accept my grandfather’s help.”

“Good. He’ll have plenty of advice for you, so listen carefully and carve every word into your bones. I don’t know what kind of man he is, but I’m sure everything he tells you will be wise and helpful…”

My words were cut off by something Xiao Shen said.

“You know him too, hyung.”[2060]

“Huh? Know what?”

“My grandfather.”

“What are you talking about? The only grandfathers I know are Butler Kim from

[2058] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man to whom he is close.
[2059] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man to whom he is close.
[2060] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man to whom he is close.

my Guild and the owner of the real-estate office outside my goshiwon."[2061]

Chairman Xiao Yang cut in with a laugh.

"Ha ha. This old man is here as well, you know."

"Oh, come on. Nice joke…"

Wait a minute.

The corners of my eyes began to twitch.

Xiao Yang. Xiao Shen. Xiao, Xiao?

I'd dismissed it because Xiao was a common surname in China, like Kim or Park in Korea, but now that I looked at them, their faces were strangely similar too.

"Don't tell me…"

"Yes. That's right."

"Even you are no different, Mr. Jin. Everyone reacts the same way."

"…I think I'm going to be sick."

"Hyung?"[2062]

"Mr. Jin?"

What kind of novel was this?

The Younger Friend I Met in China Turned Out to Be the Chinese Chairman's Grandson.

Even the title sounded ridiculous.

Why was everyone I met born with a silver spoon in their mouth?

After a brief bout of panic, I finally managed to force out my voice.

"Oh. I see."

"I am grateful to you not only as Chairman, but also as a grandfather reunited with his grandson. It is a debt this old man could never repay in a lifetime."

"Ah… No need to rush."

Apparently, I had saved the Chinese Chairman's grandson without even realizing it.

Still dazed, I exchanged final farewells with grandfather and grandson. Then my gaze fell on someone else.

Wei Fenghu.

I wasn't imagining the emptiness in his smile.

Unlike his superior, he had lost someone of his own blood whom he loved.

We looked at each other in silence for a moment, then spoke at the same time.

"Goodbye."

"Take care, Mr. Jin. You have truly worked hard."

[2061] A *goshiwon* is a type of inexpensive housing in South Korea, usually consisting of a very small rented room.

[2062] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man to whom he is close.

It was a brief exchange, but it was enough.

“Well, then.”

I gave everyone a slight bow and followed Team Leader Choi onto the waiting aircraft.

Mom looked me over with an expression that was equal parts anxious and delighted. Meanwhile, Hayeon had taken advantage of the distraction to sip champagne. When our eyes met, she gave me a sheepish smile.

“Oppa,[2063] want a glass?”

“What do you mean, a glass? You’re a minor. Hey, take that away from her.”

The Skeleton King, already in human form and seated nearby, ignored me completely. He muttered in a gloomy voice.

“It won’t stand… I’m a eunuch…”

Team Leader Choi, seated beside him, offered a few words of consolation.

“Keep your chin up. Next time, I’ll ask Mr. Johnson to do something about it.”

“R-Really?”

I nearly smacked him, but a quiet laugh escaped me instead.

At last, I felt as if I were back where I belonged.

My beloved family, whom I love more than anyone, along with my colleagues and friends.

Even though we were inside a chartered plane rather than a house, I felt an indescribable sense of comfort.

Yes. This is enough.

“We will now begin takeoff. Passengers in the cabin, please…”

An announcement rang out, and the aircraft rose toward the sky under the escort of the flight formation.

After we had spent a long while laughing, talking, and sharing stories, I sensed that the time had come.

I watched everyone sleeping soundly from the fatigue that had built up, then lay back in my plush seat.

Login.

Ding.

With the familiar notification, darkness covered my vision, and I set off.

Toward another world and another group of people waiting for me far away.

[2063] *Oppa* is a Korean term a woman uses for an older brother or an older man to whom she is close.

Chapter 435

Night had fallen deep enough to swallow even the last glow of sunset. A boy sat at the bow, staring into the black river, when he abruptly spoke.

“What brings you here?”

“I thought I’d have a drink while gazing at the Yangtze. Didn’t realize someone had beaten me to the spot.”

Behind the boy, an old man barely five feet tall appeared like a ghost, without so much as a whisper. He shook the gourd in his hand and grinned.

“Well? Want some?”

“Excessive drinking is harmful to the body. You should abstain.”

“Don’t be like that. Have a drink with me. The atmosphere is nice.”

“It would be even better if I were alone.”

“What a mouth on such a green little brat. An elder’s been talking to you all this time, and you haven’t even bothered to look at him.”

The boy frowned. Dark clouds gathered over his handsome face—a face bright enough to evoke a clear blue sky—and lightning flashed across it.

Then, instead of his usual clear voice, a low, sunken voice slipped between his lips.

“That’s enough.”

A pale-blue gleam shone from his eyes in the darkness.

There was no trace left of Mungyeong, the bright and cheerful young medical apprentice.

In his place stood the peerless martial artist known as the Slaughter Saint, a savage beast baring its claws.

But he wasn’t the only monster aboard.

“Oh, how frightening.”

The old man curled up the corners of his mouth without a care in the world, standing before an aura powerful enough to freeze even an ordinary Peak master stiff as a statue. Then Fire King Jeok Cheongang tossed him the gourd.

“Drop the little-brat act. It doesn’t suit you. Wet your throat.”

Mungyeong caught the gourd as it drifted lazily toward him and answered in a dry voice.

“Not interested.”

“What, are you still too young to drink?”

“I quit. A long time ago.”

“Must’ve been when you started playing medical apprentice.”

“…Don’t you sleep?”

“You get less sleep when you’re old. Like someone I know.”

Mungyeong shook his head slightly. Taciturn by nature and unaccustomed to showing emotion, he had always found Jeok Cheongang difficult to talk to. If he didn't want to deal with the man, his best option was to leave.

"You going?"

"That's none of your business."

"What about the liquor?"

Mungyeong tossed the gourd into the river. The rolling waters of the Yangtze swallowed it in an instant.

"I finished it."

"…If you didn't want it, you could've at least given it back. What a nasty old man."

Mungyeong's gaze sharpened as he walked past Jeok Cheongang.

The Slaughter Saint no longer existed. Now he was merely an ordinary young medical apprentice, the sort one might find anywhere.

"Your tongue is too loose."

"There aren't any ears listening, so what does it matter? Besides, after coming all this way, why bother hiding your identity?"

Mungyeong did not answer.

No—he couldn't.

Why had he done it?

Had it been nothing more than a momentary impulse?

Even the cold reason that had never wavered through countless acts of killing could not explain it.

"I see. You still haven't found the answer yourself."

Mungyeong remained silent for a moment before replying.

"We're merely traveling together."

"I understand. That was how it started for me too. Then I met one bizarre bastard, and he completely ruined my later years."

Mungyeong had a good idea who this "bizarre bastard" was, and he could think of no better description.

He had encountered every manner of person and incident in the turbulent martial world, yet that bastard was unlike anyone he had ever seen.

"Jin Taekyung."

"So you do know him. Well, how could you not?"

"He's an unusual one. He's reached an impressive realm for his age."

The corner of Jeok Cheongang's mouth twitched.

"Ahem. Impressive, my ass. He's just lucky. In terms of pure martial talent, he can't compare to the Sword Saint's Disciple. The kid doesn't seem to realize it yet, but he's already completed all the preparations necessary to open his Middle Dantian."

Mungyeong recalled the young man who had spent the entire journey performing tricks with a snake.

He also remembered the sight of that same young man at the Sichuan Tang Clan, scattering dazzling Sword Force despite being barely past twenty.

“That boy was impressive too. No—he did seem impressively insane. In terms of talent alone, he’s definitely a step above Jin Taekyung.”

“What!”

“…?”

“Ah.”

Mungyeong stared at Jeok Cheongang for a moment, then clicked his tongue.

“You certainly dote on your Disciple.”

“Disciple?”

Jeok Cheongang paused before clearing his throat.

“Ahem. Well. He might be my Disciple, or he might not…”

“What kind of nonsense is that?”

“No, well… The circumstances are somewhat complicated. You see, what happened was…”

Mungyeong suddenly felt a headache coming on.

It had been only a few days since an unheard-of group called Dark Heaven had dyed Sichuan red with blood.

His thoughts were tangled enough already. Listening to a story about this bizarre master and disciple threatened to give him seasickness he had never suffered before.

“If you have no further business with me, I’ll be leaving. I hope nothing like this happens again.”

Mungyeong tossed out the words and started toward the cabin.

“Thank you. For saving the kid.”

“…”

“I mean it.”

Mungyeong did not answer. He opened the cabin door and went inside. Jeok Cheongang grumbled behind him about what a prickly old man he was, but Mungyeong ignored him and sat on a hard wooden berth.

On the berth a few paces away, a passenger who had claimed the spot long ago was fast asleep.

Mungyeong stared at the motionless Jin Taekyung and thought,

He really is a bizarre one.

Perhaps that was why even the way he slept was strange. At first, his breathing had been so faint that Mungyeong wondered whether he had used the Turtle Breath Technique.

And that wasn't all. Jin Taekyung possessed a Heavenly Martial Physique, a constitution that appeared perhaps once every few hundred years.

Jeok Cheongang had even made the unbelievable claim that Jin Taekyung's body was steadily becoming more perfect.

Absurd.

Why was the Heavenly Martial Physique called the Heavenly Martial Physique?

Because it was the most perfect body for learning martial arts—a martial constitution bestowed by heaven itself.

The word *perfect* meant there was nothing to add and nothing to take away. Jeok Cheongang had surely misjudged the matter because his eyes were clouded by his foolish affection for his Disciple.

Still, there's no denying he's an impressive bastard. Or should that be bastards?

Cheongpung lay asleep on the berth right beside Jin Taekyung, drool running from his mouth.

His lips moved as if he were eating. On closer inspection, Mungyeong discovered that Cheongpung was sucking on the head of the snake he always carried beside him and mumbling in his sleep.

"Dumplings, roast duck, and mooncakes[2064] too, please…"

"…"

"Lots and lots, please…"

What in the world had happened while Mungyeong was away?

Mungyeong looked back and forth between Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung with an awkward expression.

These are the ones destined to illuminate the future of Murim?

Even in Mungyeong's eyes, the pair had already gone far beyond the level of mere young prodigies.

They were peerless geniuses who had broken through the wall into Supreme Peak despite being barely past twenty.

If either of them opened their Middle Dantian before turning thirty, then…

This is…

Mungyeong's eyes twitched as he studied Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung more closely.

When? No, how?

He sprang to his feet like lightning and hurriedly took Jin Taekyung's pulse.

The instant he sent internal energy through the Mingmen acupoint, an utterly unbelievable reality unfolded before him. His thoughts ground to a halt, leaving only one fact circling endlessly through his mind.

His Middle Dantian… is open?

[2064] Mooncakes are filled Chinese pastries traditionally eaten during the Mid-Autumn Festival.

Even the Unshakable Mind he had cultivated over many years failed him.

And just as Mungyeong stared blankly into space, a voice spoke.

“What are you doing?”

Mungyeong lowered his gaze and found a pair of eyes looking up at him.

Jin Taekyung’s gaze moved from Mungyeong’s hand against the Mingmen acupoint on his back to the other hand resting against his chest, directly over his Middle Dantian.

Then he opened his mouth.

“What the fuck?”

Mungyeong answered with complete sincerity.

“It’s a misunderstanding.”

“More like, ‘Oh yeah.‘”

“Calm down and listen to me…”

Jin Taekyung responded to his sincerity with a shout loud enough to wake everyone aboard the swift ship.

“Old Master!”

Boom!

The cabin door exploded into ash, revealing Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

In the dead of night, the peaceful silence of the Yangtze was shattered.

Mu Song, known as Ship-Fire Boy, was the Disciple of the Seafaring King—the Alliance Leader of the Yangtze River Channel League—and the Stronghold Lord of Water Dragon Stronghold, which ruled the rivers of Sichuan. He cried out with a face as though the sky had fallen.

“No! My swift ship!”

I quietly looked away, while the Slaughter Saint—no, Mungyeong—suddenly announced that he had medicine to prepare and left.

Jeok Cheongang, who had burned one of Mu Song’s swift ships to ashes, patted him on the shoulder.

“It’s fine. You can always build another ship.”

“No! Noooo!”

“Come now, I said it’s fine. With enough people and gold, a ship can be thrown together in no time.”

“It isn’t that simple! That wasn’t an ordinary ship. It was a special swift ship that only our Yangtze River Channel League can build! To make another, we’d have to contact headquarters, bring in craftsmen, and pour a thousand gold into it…”

Mu Song’s furious voice gradually faded.

Jeok Cheongang was watching him with an ominous smile.

Scorching Yang Qi already blazed around his fist.

“You’d pour a thousand gold into it, and then what?”

Mu Song closed his mouth.

He was clearly weighing whether to pour a thousand gold into rebuilding the swift ship or pour his own blood into the Yangtze.

In the end, it came down to money or his life. The choice wasn’t difficult.

“…I was about to say that even after pouring a thousand gold into it, we’d still have money left over, Great Hero Jeok.”

“Right? Business is good around here, isn’t it?”

Mu Song’s ferocious face twisted. The sight would have made ordinary people piss themselves down to their innards, but despite appearances, that was his smile. As befitted a pure-blooded river bandit, he simply had a vicious face.

Despite his size, he rubbed his palms together ingratiatingly.

“Oh, don’t even ask. We’d rob more if there were anything left to take.”

“Yes, yes. Good to hear. Since it came to mind, let me say this: don’t rob people too much. It’s none of my business, but they need to make a living too.”

“Yes, yes.”

“I apologize again for this incident. I made a small mistake while training.”

“Of course. Such things happen. Were you hurt anywhere?”

“No. But my qi has felt weak lately. It would be nice to have something to chew on…”

“We recently acquired a few fine specimens of He Shou Wu.[2065] It seems they’ve finally found their rightful owner.”

“The owner is you. This old man is merely a guest. Ha ha. Still, if you insist on giving them to me, I’ll gratefully accept.”

Jeok Cheongang patted Mu Song’s shoulder a few more times, then turned and scowled at me.

“Damn it. Why did you cause such a commotion in the middle of the night?”

I answered calmly.

“Imagine waking up and finding some man touching your chest and back.”

“I’d burn him down to bone ash.”

“Yes. That’s what happened. How was I supposed to think straight in that situation? Besides, you smashed everything to pieces before I could stop you.”

The result had been fiery.

[2065] He Shou Wu is a root used in traditional Chinese medicine.

True to his title as the Slaughter Saint, Mungyeong had evaded Jeok Cheongang's attacks with ghostlike movements, while the Flame Divine Palm's searing heat had set the swift ship ablaze.

Jeok Cheongang frowned and muttered,

"I thought that bastard hadn't kicked his old habits."

"Well, they say a habit formed at three lasts until eighty."

"He passed eighty a long time ago, didn't he?"

"Then let's say a habit formed at three lasts until a hundred."

Mungyeong, who had been rushing around checking on everyone who had fallen into the water, whispered as he passed us.

"If you don't want to die, shut your mouth."

Instead of shutting my mouth, I shouted loudly enough for everyone to hear.

"Mungyeong, what did you say?"

"Yes, yes?"

"No. Didn't you just say something to me?"

"That couldn't… possibly be. You must have misheard me."

"Right?"

"Yes, yes."

"Then keep doing your work. Thanks for your hard work."

"Thank… you."

This was what happened when you committed too hard to the bit.

Anyway, it sure was a spectacle immediately after coming back.

This is Murim.

I shook my head as I gazed out over the Yangtze stretching endlessly into the distance.

Chapter 436

The Yangtze.

As its name suggested, the Yangtze was immense. In terms of length especially, few rivers on the continent could compare.

It crossed five provinces in all—Sichuan, Chongqing, Hubei, Anhui, and finally Jiangsu. As a vital hub of waterborne transportation, it would occupy a large portion of our journey.

“Our current plan is to follow one of the Yangtze’s tributaries to Hubei, then disembark and continue overland to Henan.”

After finishing his brief explanation, Jin Wikyung slowly looked over the group, including me.

“Does anyone have any questions?”

Whoosh!

The instant he finished speaking, one hand shot into the air.

Judging by how fast it went up, its owner could have been a model student bursting with academic enthusiasm. In reality, the hand belonged to a Supreme Peak master notorious throughout Murim as a thug on a national scale.

“There’s something this old man has been wondering for a while.”

“I’m all ears, Great Hero Jeok.”

“So what you’re saying is…”

Jeok Cheongang continued with a deeply sour expression.

“It sounds like you’re telling us to grow old and die on this damn Yangtze. Am I mistaken?”

That was the Fire King for you. He really knew how to bring the heat.

Jin Wikyung swallowed hard at Jeok Cheongang’s way of speaking, which came crashing forward like an eight-ton truck[2066] with a broken steering wheel.

“How could that be, Great Hero Jeok? This is simply the itinerary decided upon at the meeting.”

“A meeting? What kind of lunatics came up with this schedule? Even at the fastest pace, it’ll take seven days and nights just to reach Hubei!”

“At the top, we have Great Hero Sword Saint Mae Jonghak, and beneath him, the Nine Sects and One Gang[2067] and the Five Great Families…”

“That’s enough. I don’t need to hear any more.”

“Pardon?”

[2066] The Korean source uses metric tons. Eight metric tons is about 8,000 kg, or 17,600 lb.

[2067] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations; the “One Gang” is the Beggars’ Sect.

"The Nine Sects and One Gang[2068] and the Five Great Families are all idiots with nothing but shit in their heads, so forget about them. I'll explain things properly to Mae Jonghak myself. Change the itinerary while there's still time. Staring at water all day is going to give me qi deviation."

In short, he was telling them to do their worst.

It was the kind of unreasonable demand only Jeok Cheongang could get away with. Not a single person here dared object to him.

Ah. There was one person who could.

Jeok Cheongang must have had the same thought, because he subtly turned his head.

His gaze met Mungyeong's in midair.

Mungyeong looked back at him with an expression that clearly said *pathetic*.

Jeok Cheongang stared at him, then tossed out a single remark.

"Hey. What are you looking at me like that for?"

"…"

"You little punk, you're still wet behind the ears. I ought to poke your eyes out and squeeze all the ink from them."

He was openly laying into him now.

Mungyeong's fist trembled.

As someone who knew his true identity, I found the sight chilling. To everyone else, however, it looked entirely different.

Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang, who had been languishing from the aftereffects of sampling the Yangtze, spoke in faint, faltering voices.

"Why are you picking on the boy? Just look at Mungyeong shaking. He's such a gentle soul…"

"I may eat stray yellow dogs, but Mungyeong couldn't kill an ant."

"…"

He probably killed people during the time it took to kill an ant.

I had heard that more than a thousand people were *officially* known to have died at the hands of the Slaughter Saint.

Even if he went around smearing Madecassol healing ointment on his sword, he still wasn't the sort of person anyone could call gentle.

"You lot… No. Forget it. Just keep living like that."

Jeok Cheongang looked ready to say something, but let out a deep sigh instead. Then he abruptly turned toward me.

"Why are you saying nothing?"

"About what?"

[2068]The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations; the "One Gang" is the Beggars' Sect.

“What else? Do you really want to keep floating around on this miserable water?”

“Oh, that.”

I scratched my chin and thought for a moment before answering.

“I don’t mind it.”

“What!”

“Little Brother!”

Jeok Cheongang and Jin Wikyung’s reactions were polar opposites. But I hadn’t said it to help Jin Wikyung. I meant it.

“There must be a reason the people in charge decided on this route. Besides, the scenery is nice.”

This was a world without environmental pollution. At dawn, a hazy mist blanketed the river, and the sight of the clear water stretching endlessly into the distance made my chest feel wide open.

When Jeok Cheongang had been unconscious, none of it had moved me at all, but…

In any case, I needed to set aside my impatience for a while and take the time to reflect and collect myself.

And there are things I need to investigate.

The mysterious patterns and symbols discovered in both worlds.

I had to find out whether my suspicions about them were correct. To do that, I had a lot to take care of while going back and forth between Murim and the modern world. If we traveled overland, the time available for that would be drastically reduced.

I tried to gently coax Jeok Cheongang around.

“It’s only a difference of a few days. Old Master—no, Master, you need to think about your health too. It hasn’t been long since you pushed yourself so hard.”

“What do you mean, pushed myself? Do you think this old man is on his deathbed?”

“Then what? Are you sixteen and in the prime of youth? A fresh-faced eighteen-year-old?”

“You little bastard!”

The instant Jeok Cheongang’s eyes flared, I hurriedly spoke.

“Martial arts! I need instruction in martial arts!”

The hand that had risen as though to smack me stopped in midair.

I didn’t miss the opening and continued.

“I’ve gained some insight recently. If we travel overland, there won’t be enough time for you to teach me.”

“Instruction…”

“There are parts I could never understand on my own, no matter how hard I rack my brain—even if I died and came back to life.”

“Is that true?”

“Yes. It’s precious instruction that only one person in all the world can give me—my master.”

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes.

“If we use our movement techniques to the fullest overland, we could reach Henan several days earlier.”

“What does that have to do with receiving instruction?”

“It has everything to do with it. Didn’t you say before that you thought Sword Saint Mae Jonghak might be stronger than this old man? By your logic, shouldn’t you reach Henan as quickly as possible and ask the Sword Saint?”

I had tossed that out to tease him, but he actually remembered it.

I pretended not to know what he was talking about.

“You must have heard me wrong. Was I drunk out of my mind that day?”

“What a load of drunken bullshit.”

“To me, Master, you’re always the best.”

“Is that so?”

Jeok Cheongang glanced sideways at Mungyeong before asking,

“Then how do I compare to the Slaughter Saint?”

“What?”

“The Slaughter Saint. The one among the Three Saints whom no one can match when it comes to killing people. How do I compare to him?”

I could feel the people around me waiting with interest for my answer.

And I could also feel someone discreetly leaking killing intent.

Ah, fuck it. I don’t know.

I swallowed hard and opened my mouth.

“He’s a total fucking pushover.”

“Hm. Perhaps this boy knows what he’s talking about.”

“I know my martial arts, don’t I? I can size someone up at a glance.”

“Ahem. Did you grease your tongue? You’re showering me with flattery when you never do anything of the sort. Do you think this old man will fall for such a shallow trick?”

“…Then why are you smiling?”

Was he Murim’s Joker?

Jeok Cheongang’s grin had stretched all the way to his ears, but he immediately schooled his expression. He couldn’t quite hide the corners of his mouth twitching as he fought back a smile.

“When did I smile?”

“You didn’t. Anyway, let’s just keep going like this.”

Jeok Cheongang already knew that I had opened my Middle Dantian. He considered it for a moment, then smacked his lips.

“Damn it. Even so, I hate water. Looks like this old man will be suffering in his twilight years.”

“…”

Had he been a Fire Pokémon in his previous life?

At this point, maybe he should change his sobriquet from the Fire King to Charizard.

“What’s with that disrespectful look?”

“Me? When?”

“Forget it. It isn’t the first or second time, anyway. It was my mistake for expecting manners from an uncouth little brat like you.”

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue and turned toward Jin Wikyung.

“You heard everything, didn’t you?”

“Yes. We will see to it that you suffer no inconvenience.”

“So what are you planning to do after taking this miserable Yangtze to Hubei? There must be a reason worth enduring all this trouble.”

“We have an important matter to attend to.”

“An important matter?”

“Would it be all right if I told you later?”

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes, but that was all.

If Jin Wikyung was speaking that way, it meant the matter was confidential—something better discussed with fewer ears around.

Jeok Cheongang might not care what other people thought, but that didn’t mean he was oblivious.

“Understood. Then are we finished here?”

Jin Wikyung politely clasped his hands.

“Thank you for your hard work.”

But one person was dissatisfied with the outcome of this brief meeting.

“W-wait a moment. Are you saying you intend to take our Water Dragon Stronghold’s swift ship all the way to Hubei?”

Jin Wikyung was about to answer the ship’s owner, Mu Song, when Jeok Cheongang stepped between them.

“Is there a problem?”

“G-Great Hero Jeok, Hubei is much too far. Even with a favorable wind, it will take more than seven days and nights…”

“You can’t leave the stronghold empty for that long?”

“Yes, yes! Exactly!”

“A body is no good if the torso and limbs are intact but the head is missing. That would be a problem.”

“Does that mean…?”

“Go as far as Sichuan.”

Mu Song’s face brightened.

“Thank you!”

“Leave the ship behind.”

“What?”

“Do you expect this old man to continue in a skiff? We can find sailors along the way. Leave this swift ship or whatever it’s called, then go back.”

Mu Song fell silent for a moment before managing to speak.

“Well…”

“What?”

“Now that I think about it, it would be better for my subordinates and me to escort you and see to your every need.”

“Good heavens, there’s really no need. I already feel bad about burning one of your ships. I’m not sure whether I should impose upon you like this.”

“…Please don’t set anything else on fire.”

“That depends on how you behave.”

Was this the tyranny of a major corporation?

In all my life, this was the first time I had ever felt sorry for a river bandit.

Mu Song clasped his hands and withdrew with a sorrowful expression.

Cheongpung quietly approached him and held out the dumpling in his hand.

Just how much had he stuffed down his throat in the meantime? Both cheeks were already on the verge of bursting.

“‘Ave one.”

“…Are you telling me to eat it? Are you giving it to me?”

“Yeah!”

Feeling the warmth of human kindness for the first time in ages, Mu Song’s eyes grew misty.

“Thank you, Young Hero Cheongpung.”

Then he stuffed the cold dumpling into his mouth in one bite.

Cheongpung swallowed what he had been chewing and smiled brightly.

“Tasty, right?”

“It truly is. It’s the best dumpling I’ve had lately. I’ll have to get some from you now and then.”

“That was the last one.”

“What? You gave me the last dumpling? Young Hero Cheongpung, you…”

“My grandpa told me that when you have something good, you should share it with other people.”

Considering how much he had eaten by himself until now, it sounded like complete bullshit. But Mu Song didn’t know that, and he was deeply moved.

“Thank you, Young Hero Cheongpung. We’ve barely even spoken, yet you’ve gone out of your way to do this for me. I didn’t know that… Sniff.”

Mu Song’s gratitude did not last long.

“My grandpa told me something else too. Whoever eats the last dumpling has to buy the next batch!”

“…”

“…”

“If we travel for one more day, we’ll reach a place called Guang’an. The dumplings sold in the market there are really good. When I traveled around the world for a year, I stayed there for a whole month because of those dumplings. Ah, no, that’s not what I meant. Grandpa said we absolutely had to stop there! He said whoever ate the last dumpling had to buy a whole bunch more!”

“…”

“…”

What a terrifying little bastard.

Now he was even selling out his grandfather to get more dumplings.

Gung Gibang, who had been watching the scene, muttered that Cheongpung would make an excellent Beggars’ Sect disciple.

Mu Song, now doomed to stop at the famous dumpling shop in Guang’an, answered with every last scrap of trust in humanity drained from his face.

“Understood.”

“Yay! Grandpa will be happy!”

Was that even human?

I was still horrified by the bottomless depths of his character when—

“You don’t look well. May I examine you for a moment?”

Fucking pushover—no, Mungyeong was looking at me with concern.

He had a large acupuncture needle hidden in one hand, pressed right against my waist.

“Uh, no. No, I’m fine. I’m not feeling—”

“You don’t look well. May I examine you for a moment?”

“I’m really fi—”

“You don’t look well. May I examine you for a moment?”

“…”

It was humiliating, but I think I just pissed myself a little.

Chapter 437

As its name suggested, a swift ship was built with speed as its top priority.

If an ordinary warship was a heavyweight, then a swift ship was closer to a welterweight.

Naturally, its hull wasn't particularly large, which meant there weren't many places aboard where you could avoid everyone else's eyes.

"Oh, dear."

"Great Hero Jin. What brings you here?"

Two river bandits who had been slacking off at the stern under the pretense of standing guard recognized me and bowed obsequiously.

I nodded gravely and opened my mouth.

"Save me…"

At that moment, something sharp poked me right in the Mingmen acupoint at the small of my back.

"Save—stay alert as you go."

"What?"

"I said, stay alert as you go. I need to discuss something with this fellow for a moment."

"Oh, I see."

No. Don't agree. Please be suspicious.

I continued speaking while shooting an urgent sidelong glance at Mungyeong, who was pressed against my side.

"Be sure to take care on your way! If anyone asks about me, tell them I'm with Mungyeong!"

"Uh, understood."

"No, not 'understood.' Oh, right! My master! If my master comes looking for me…"

"I don't think that's likely."

Mungyeong cut me off with an innocent smile.

"It seems there's something urgent to discuss with Great Hero Jin Wikyung. In any case, we've only come to see a patient for a moment, so please don't concern yourself with us. Go on and rest in the cabin. I'll let you know afterward."

"Works for us."

Nothing was sweeter than authorized slacking in the middle of a boring guard shift.

[2069] Sound Transmission is a martial-arts technique for sending words privately to a chosen listener.

The river bandits smiled and left, delighted to lounge in the cool shade. As for the Sound Transmission[2069] I was preparing to send as a last resort, a single sentence from Mungyeong stopped me cold.

"You seem to have three or four lives."

"…"

"You have two choices. Answer every question this old man asks from now on, or, if you'd rather not, quietly keep your mouth shut."

I asked, just in case.

"What happens if I choose the second option?"

"You'll go to Hubei."

"That doesn't sound too ba—"

Mungyeong calmly continued before I could finish.

"You'll drift all the way to Hubei while sunk at the bottom of the Yangtze. Quietly."

"…I thought you said you'd stopped killing."

"That depends on this old man's will. It's none of your concern."

What the fuck? It isn't like he's trying to quit smoking…

Dumbfounded, I protested again.

"You're the Divine Physician. Are you really threatening to kill me?"

"I'm the former Divine Physician. I passed that name on to my Disciple long ago. So? What's your answer?"

I glared at Mungyeong.

"Do you really think I'll give in to a threat like this?"

"Of course."

"You read me perfectly. I'll answer every question with the utmost sincerity."

"…"

Mungyeong seemed momentarily at a loss for words. After a long silence, he finally spoke.

"I've seen all kinds, but never anyone as strange as you."

"From everyone else's perspective, I'd say we're both equally strange. Send a messenger-pigeon survey to everyone in Murim and ask which one of us is the bigger freak."

"Freak?"

"My tongue slipped. Sorry."

The aura Mungyeong let loose made every hair on my body stand on end.

He silently watched me swallow hard, then tossed out a single phrase.

"Middle Dantian."

"Huh?"

“Until a few days ago—no, until half a day ago—your Middle Dantian was closed. What trick did you use to accomplish such a great feat overnight?”

So this was why he’d called me aside.

I knew he’d noticed.

The hierarchy of martial realms was perfectly vertical.

It was like sitting in a lofty place and looking down upon everything beneath you.

The Fire King and the Slaughter Saint were peerless masters who had climbed the highest peaks in the rugged mountain range known as Murim.

Both had opened their Middle Dantians long before a person named Jin Taekyung had even been born into Murim. Of course they had noticed the change in me.

The problem was…

What am I supposed to tell him?

It wasn’t as though I had farted in my sleep and somehow opened my Middle Dantian. Other people could attain that kind of enlightenment only through grueling training or while hovering between life and death.

I hesitated, then spotted the large acupuncture needle in Mungyeong’s hand and hurriedly answered.

“It just happened.”

“What?”

“It just opened.”

“…And you expect me to believe that?”

Obviously not.

So I threw in a cliché straight out of a martial arts novel.

“Actually, I did have a strange dream.”

I glanced around and lowered my voice. Mungyeong’s brow furrowed.

“A dream?”

“Yes. A white-haired old man who looked incredibly ancient suddenly started swinging a sword at me without warning. I didn’t even realize it was a dream, so I focused on dodging first.”

It didn’t matter whether it was a spear, a sword, or a back-scratcher. This was a world overrun with all kinds of superstition.

A white-haired old man with the air of an immortal appearing in my dream was enough to pique anyone’s curiosity.

Sure enough, Mungyeong asked with the eager expression of a webnovel reader waiting for the next update.

“And then?”

“I summoned every last ounce of strength I had and fought back, but I was no match for him. No matter how I attacked, he dodged without a care. And

whenever I tried to get away, he glided up to me like a ghost and slashed me with his sword. Swish, slash—ugh! You know what I mean?"

"You didn't realize it was a dream?"

"I didn't have time to realize anything. Besides, the pain felt incredibly real. Before I knew it, he'd cut me hundreds of times. I thought, *So this is how I die.* But then I noticed I hadn't shed a single drop of blood. That was when I realized it was a dream."

"Continue."

"But it was driving me insane. He kept cutting me, and it hurt like hell. Even after I realized it was a dream, I couldn't wake up."

"Yes. Exactly."

Mungyeong flinched as if he'd been cut himself.

This guy gives surprisingly good reactions.

Having reconfirmed the instincts of the webnovel reader hidden behind the terrifying name of Slaughter Saint, I continued without hesitation.

"I don't even know how much time passed. Days? Months? I lost all sense of time as he cut me over and over and I kept swinging back. Then, all of a sudden, I felt something strange."

"Explain it in detail. What was it like?"

This part, at least, I could describe in detail and tell him the truth. It was something I had personally experienced during my battle with the Arch Lich.

An ordinary person might have dismissed my explanation as vague, airy nonsense, but after listening, Mungyeong quietly muttered, "Enlightenment. You gained a fortuitous encounter."

"Whoa, I've got goose bumps. He said something similar."

"He left you a message?"

"Yes. He looked at me and smiled for the first time, then said that this fortuitous encounter was a blessing he was bestowing upon me and that I should devote myself even more fully to my training."

"Was that all?"

"Huh?"

"Did he say anything else?"

"Uh, well…"

Hold on. I didn't plan for this.

I'd squeezed this entire story out of my brain on the spot, and I'd already used everything I had prepared.

But Mungyeong was demanding another installment, and I had nothing left in reserve.

The problem was, Mungyeong wasn't an ordinary reader.

He was the Slaughter Saint.

What happens if I end it here?

What else? I'd sink to the bottom of the Yangtze and drift all the way to Hubei.

As Mungyeong's eyes narrowed, I hurriedly opened my mouth.

"He did say one more thing."

"What did he say?"

"Well, that is…"

Fuck it. I don't know.

I swallowed dryly and cautiously spoke.

"You have to suffer to be a Murim man."

"What?"

"He really said that. Those exact words. Then he climbed onto his sword and flew off…"

"I can sense profound wisdom in those words."

"Huh?"

I let out a stupefied sound while keeping a wary eye on the large needle in Mungyeong's hand.

What the hell is he talking about now?

When I raised my head, I saw Mungyeong murmuring under his breath and nodding slightly as though he were groaning.

After muttering something unintelligible, he suddenly spoke.

"It was Lü Yan."[2070]

"I know about stomach cancer and lung cancer, but… are you sick somewhere?"

"…You don't know Lü Yan?"

Mungyeong looked at me as though I were insane, then continued.

"Lü Yan. His courtesy name was Dongbin, and his Taoist name was Chunyangzi. He attained his own Dao[2071] and reached the realm of an immortal. People called him the Sword Immortal."

"Wait. You mean Lü Dongbin?"

"You finally understand."

I might not have known Lü Yan, but I knew Sword Immortal Lü Dongbin. Along with Jang Samfeng of Wudang and Bodhidharma of Shaolin Temple, he was one of the three perennial fixtures of martial arts novels.

Mungyeong continued, his expression deadly serious.

"The old man you saw in your dream must have been Lü Dongbin. He vanished by riding his sword at the end, so he must have been the Sword Immortal."

[2070] The Korean reading of Lü Yan's name, *Yeo-am*, ends in *am*, the Korean word for "cancer"—hence Taekyung's misunderstanding.

[2071] *Dao* means "Way"; in Taoist thought, it can refer to a path of spiritual cultivation.

“Uh… I suppose so.”

I’d only made that part up because it sounded cool, but somehow it had turned into this.

I knew from novels that there was an immortal named Lü Dongbin, but this was the first I’d heard of him being a master of sword-riding arts.

Talk about making the facts fit the theory.

That was exactly what was happening.

Having decided that the old man from my dream—or rather, my story—was Lü Dongbin, Mungyeong was now fitting everything together with absolute seriousness without even realizing it.

“Did his beard reach down to his chest?”

“Yes.”

“How tall was he?”

“He was short.”

“Boy! I’m asking how short!”

“Oh, just short. I was being cut to pieces the entire time. When was I supposed to study his height?”

Mungyeong nodded and let most of my answers pass, but there was one dangerously close call.

“What did he carry besides the sword?”

“Let me think… His scabbard.”

“Do you want to die? Of course he had that. Was there nothing else?”

“…I think that was all.”

The light in Mungyeong’s eyes darkened.

“Lü Dongbin did not carry only a sword. He always held a Taoist fly-whisk in his right hand.”

“…!”

“Have you been lying to this old man all along?”

It was a life-or-death crisis.

I had no idea why a man known as the Sword Immortal would walk around carrying a fly-whisk, but my top priority was avoiding Mungyeong’s suspicions. Without letting a single change cross my face, I answered.

“Everything I said was true.”

“Then why does your description contradict Lü Dongbin’s usual appearance?”

“He must have left his fly-whisk behind today.”

“What kind of bullshi—”

“No, wait. Have you ever seen Lü Dongbin?”

“…!”

"I have."

Fuck, I'm the one who saw him. What are you going to do about it?

Seizing the advantage, I bore down on Mungyeong while he was momentarily at a loss for words.

"And did I ever say he was Lü Dongbin? I thought he was just some old man. You were the one who called him Lü Dongbin first."

"You?"

"That isn't the point. That's what happened, isn't it? Honestly, I don't care whether he was Lü Dongbin or Kim Dongbin. I met some unidentified old man in a dream and gained a fortuitous encounter. That's all. But you're hounding me like I've committed some terrible crime, so I really… Ha."

"…"

"Can you see the tears in my eyes? I don't want to act like this as a grown man, but this is so unfair I'm actually crying."

The truth was, I was scared.

That, combined with the self-loathing of having to invent lies under threat despite committing no crime, eventually sent a tear rolling down my cheek.

Is this what life is?

I had wet myself below earlier, and now I was wetting myself above.

It had started as an act, but somehow it had become real. Bewilderment flashed across Mungyeong's nearly expressionless face.

"You little bastard. What trick are you pulling?"

"Ugh, there you go again. I'm done. I quit. I answered all your questions, so I'm leaving."

"You're leaving?"

"I don't care anymore. Do whatever you want. Kill me, spare me, use Impure World Reincarnation[2072] on me—whatever."

Just as I was about to take a step, someone appeared while scattering a powerful aura.

"What the hell is this dogshit?"

The gazes of the Fire King and the Slaughter Saint collided in midair.

[2072] Impure World Reincarnation is a resurrection technique from *Naruto*.

Chapter 438

Jeok Cheongang's eyes blazed as he glared at Mungyeong.

"How dare you threaten someone else's dis, dis… Disciple Taekyung while this old man was away?"

"…What the hell is 'Disciple Taekyung'?"

My tears dried up at once as I muttered in disbelief. Jeok Cheongang roared.

"Quiet!"

Mungyeong and I answered at the same time.

"You're louder, Old Master. You're practically shouting 'Disciple Taekyung' from the center of the world."

"Judging by that voice, you'll live another ten years."

Did he roast a train smokestack in an air fryer and eat it?

It was a good thing Mungyeong had used his internal energy to raise a qi barrier and keep the sound from escaping. Otherwise, people would have gathered around us long ago.

Jeok Cheongang's face flushed bright red. Mungyeong quietly clicked his tongue.

"We merely had a brief conversation. What would this old man gain from threatening such a young pup?"

Jeok Cheongang turned toward me.

"You answer me. Is what that old man said true?"

"It's true that we only talked, but he said I'd sink to the bottom of the Yangtze if he didn't like my answer."

At my tattling, Mungyeong shamelessly added,

"Of course, I did frighten him a little."

"Would you look at this damned old man! You think you'll get away with pulling something like this?"

"Calm yourself. I merely had something to ask him about his Middle Dantian."

Jeok Cheongang had leaned forward as though he were about to charge, but he stopped dead.

"Middle Dantian?"

"Yes. Surely you didn't fail to notice."

"…"

"Opening one's Middle Dantian in such a short time is impossible. Even heavenly fortune cannot explain it."

Jeok Cheongang looked back and forth between Mungyeong and me, then let out a short laugh.

"So it was nothing."

"…What?"

"So you're trying to say that the boy learned demonic martial arts or something?"

"That…"

"I'll put it simply. No."

Mungyeong was left speechless by Jeok Cheongang's calm, utterly confident response. Jeok Cheongang crooked a finger at me.

"What are you waiting for? Come here."

"Huh?"

"You asked me to oversee your training, didn't you? We're starting now."

"Oh. Right."

The situation moved on so smoothly that even I was caught off guard. As though he had read my thoughts, Jeok Cheongang asked,

"I am curious, though. How exactly did you open your Middle Dantian?"

"Uh, well. I had a dream, and there was this old man with a sword…"

"Did you meet the Sword Immortal Lü Dongbin?"

"…Well, judging by what that guy over there said, maybe."

"You gained a fortuitous encounter. It seems the heavens are helping you. Things beyond human understanding do happen in this world from time to time."

Jeok Cheongang was looking at me, but his answer was directed at Mungyeong.

After tossing out that remark for Mungyeong to hear, Jeok Cheongang suddenly swung his wrinkled hand.

Smack!

"Ow! Why did you hit me?"

"You irritated me, so I felt like hitting you. Got a problem with that?"

"What if I do?"

"Then you can take another hit."

Whack!

"Aaagh!"

"You blockheaded brat. Quit whining. Stop fooling around and follow me."

Can I really just leave like this?

I glanced at Mungyeong, who stood there wearing an unreadable expression. A thunderous shout immediately crashed down on me.

"And yet, you brat!"

"Okay, okay, I get it. Please stop shouting."

"Dragging your feet like this, do you even intend to train?"

I turned my back on Mungyeong and followed close behind Jeok Cheongang, whispering,

"But aren't you going to ask anything else?"

Jeok Cheongang answered gruffly without turning around.

“About what?”

“No, I mean… the Middle Dantian…”

“Stop talking nonsense and follow me. From now on, don’t go anywhere near that old man.”

“Yes, sir.”

That was exactly what I wanted. I wasn’t some Mermaid Princess of the Yangtze, and I had absolutely no intention of getting on his bad side and drifting all the way to Hubei with the fish.

“If I catch you in a situation like this again, I’ll teach you a lesson. Understand?”

“…I’m the victim here. Why are you blaming me?”

“Quiet. I was about to smash everything to pieces earlier, but I held myself back.”

“Come to think of it, you really did show restraint.”

“Would the ship have survived if I hadn’t?”

“True. We should take Senior Mu Song’s circumstances into consideration. Did you see his face when the swift ship caught fire?”

Jeok Cheongang whipped his head around and frowned.

“What kind of nonsense are you talking about? Why should this old man care about those river bandits’ circumstances?”

“Huh?”

“If we lose another ship here, we’ll have to move everyone aboard to a different one. All that extra weight would slow us down.”

“…Oh.”

“Think before you speak. We need to get off this wretched Yangtze as quickly as possible. It’s damp, it rocks, and it never seems to end.”

What a lovely personality.

I watched the Fire Pokémon walk away, shuddering from head to toe, when a thought suddenly occurred to me.

If we burn everything down, couldn’t we travel by land?

I decided not to say it. Jeok Cheongang was more than capable of actually doing it.

I did my best to ignore Mungyeong’s prickling gaze on the back of my head as I followed Jeok Cheongang.

The swift ship cut through the water without slowing.

Every vessel that saw the flag of the Yangtze River Channel League flying high above the deck hurriedly cleared a path. Even the government warships with their cozy ties to the League were no exception.

The river bandits knew the lower Yangtze and its waterways like the backs of their hands. Following Mu Song's orders, they pulled hard on their oars, while the sails billowed wide in the wind blowing from far away.

Like the churning waters of the Yangtze, the hours of that day rushed past.

And…

Just as he had the previous night, Mungyeong sat at the bow and gazed out at the Yangtze shrouded in darkness. When his uninvited guest arrived again, he spoke in a low voice.

"You're later than I expected."

"It took time to find the liquor that fellow Mu Song—or whatever his name is—had hidden away. He fought tooth and nail to keep it from me until the very end."

Jeok Cheongang perched on the railing and broke the seal on a small jar he had taken out as carefully as though it were a treasured family heirloom.

A fragrant aroma of liquor immediately spread through the air, cracking Mungyeong's usually impassive expression.

"Jiannan Chun?"

"Of course. When you come to Sichuan, you drink Jiannan Chun. This is what makes the trip worthwhile."

"That doesn't seem like ordinary Jiannan Chun."

"According to that fellow, it was a gift from his Master. A man as eminent as the Seafaring King wouldn't have given his Disciple ordinary liquor… Thanks to him, this old man's tongue is enjoying a rare treat."

Jeok Cheongang lifted the jar to his mouth and gulped down the liquor, then smacked his lips.

"Damn, that's good. Want a drink?"

Mungyeong stared intently at the jar of Jiannan Chun, then shook his head.

"…I believe I told you I quit drinking a long time ago."

"You took too long to answer. For an old man known as the greatest assassin in history, you make your thoughts awfully easy to read."

"That still makes me better than an old man who carries on like a reckless brat at his age."

"What did you say?"

"Enough nonsense. Let's get to the point. You have something to say to me, don't you?"

Jeok Cheongang's visit the previous day had been unexpected. Today was different.

Several shichen[2073] earlier, Jeok Cheongang had used Sound Transmission to tell Mungyeong that he would come. Mungyeong had been waiting for him.

"You're impatient. That isn't very assassin-like, either."

[2073] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"I'm a medical apprentice, not an assassin."

"Then call yourself a life-taker."

"Disciple and Master alike. Your words and actions are exactly the same."

Ignoring Mungyeong's frown, Jeok Cheongang took another drink and wiped his mouth with his sleeve before answering.

"Our words and actions may resemble each other, but we're worlds apart. That brat is a monster who has strayed beyond all common sense."

Mungyeong nodded silently.

He couldn't disagree with the word *monster*. Reaching the Supreme Peak realm just after passing the age of twenty was astonishing enough, but Jin Taekyung had taken another step before he had even caught his breath.

When did he reach the Supreme Peak realm?

Mungyeong searched his memories of the distant past.

He had been younger then—sharper and quieter than he was now. He had devoted his heart and soul entirely to martial arts.

Sometimes covertly and sometimes through direct confrontation, he had accumulated experience through countless real battles. At last, he had set foot in that exalted realm said to admit only the chosen.

I was in my mid-thirties.

Even Mungyeong, hailed as the greatest assassin in history and known as the Slaughter Saint, had not reached the Supreme Peak realm until after turning thirty.

He had opened his Middle Dantian several years later, when he was nearing forty.

Yet Jin Taekyung had left his mark on Murim's long history when he was barely past twenty.

In Mungyeong's estimation, this could only be the work of demonic, heterodox arts—and an unparalleled demonic martial art at that.

"I have a feeling this conversation will take a while."

"No, it'll be over quickly. This old man doesn't have much to say."

Mungyeong's gaze darkened at Jeok Cheongang's answer.

"Why not?"

"What can I say about something I've never seen or heard of? There's nothing to do but accept it."

"Surely you don't believe that nonsense about the Sword Immortal Lü Dongbin appearing in his dream and granting him enlightenment."

"It may have happened, or it may not have. But even if it's true, it wouldn't be all that surprising. Heh heh."

"Fire King!"

The thunderous cry struck the qi barrier surrounding the two men and reverberated with a deep hum.

But the anger that flashed across Mungyeong's face vanished without a trace at Jeok Cheongang's next words.

"Two years."

"…What did you say?"

"It took that brat only two years to break through the wall of the Supreme Peak realm and open his Middle Dantian. If this old man were Lü Dongbin, I would have come to him in person instead of appearing in a dream, saying, 'What an incredible fellow there is in the lower world.'"

Mungyeong first questioned his own ears, then Jeok Cheongang's state of mind.

But the small old man before him continued speaking, his eyes clearer than Mungyeong had ever seen them.

"Don't doubt him. When you face that brat, erase everything you've seen and heard throughout your life from your mind. Do you understand what I mean?"

"…!"

"Taekyung. That boy and the Sword Saint's Disciple are Divine Dragons in the truest sense. No one has ever seen one. All anyone can do is imagine what they must be like."

Whoosh.

White foam splashed against the bow. A long time passed before Mungyeong broke the silence.

"I can't believe it."

"I didn't tell you to believe it. I only told you to accept it."

"Every part of that is impossible."

"There's one truth this old man learned while growing older for no good reason. You can't control another person's heart."

Jeok Cheongang had learned that only after sending his first Disciple away.

And only after he met a young man by chance and, one day, truly accepted him into his heart did he realize something else.

The pain that throbbed whenever he remembered that day had grown faint.

"You'll understand if you keep watching him. Just as I did."

Mungyeong silently watched Jeok Cheongang's back as he rose from the railing and ambled away. Then he suddenly spoke.

"What is that brat doing right now?"

"Taekyung?"

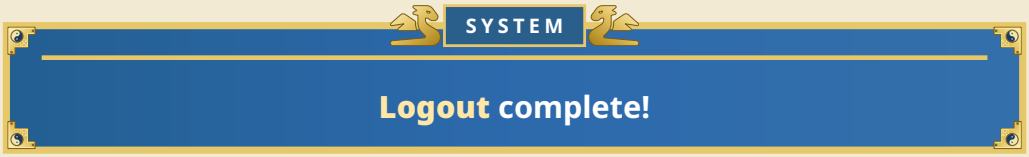
Jeok Cheongang turned his head and laughed heartily beneath the moonlight.

"He's sleeping like the dead."

If training at Fire Gate Cavern had been a marathon, this was a sprint relay.

During the little over a week it would take to reach Hubei, I had decided to travel back and forth between the modern world and Murim, juggling two lives.

Ding.



I opened my eyes to the familiar chime. I was inside the private jet bound for Korea.

I saw people sleeping soundly from all the fatigue they had accumulated, along with one monster staring at me with his eyes wide open.

“What are you looking at, you punk?”

The Skeleton King answered.

“So that was it. Hmm. Do all humans sleep like the dead, just like you?”

“I’m special.”

“Not weird?”

Whack!

This bastard really went out of his way to get hit.

Chapter 439

Smack!

The blow caught the Skeleton King square in the forehead, sending him staggering.

But only for a moment. He lowered his head, which had snapped back from the impact, into its proper position and grinned smugly.

“Heh heh. That barely tickled.”

“Oh, right. Your disguise is so convincing that I forgot for a second.”

There was no way an undead monster—already dead, whether it had a soul or not—could feel pain. Magic Johnson really had done one hell of a job with his full-body plastic surgery.

As I clicked my tongue softly, the Skeleton King shrugged.

“You must not place this king on the same level as a weak human.”

“Of course I don’t. You’re an undead monster.”

“An undead monster? This king is Stone-King, born and raised in Atlanta, Georgia, in the United States!”

“Hey, hey!”

What the hell was wrong with this lunatic? Why was he suddenly shouting?

I hurriedly raised my internal energy to block the sound, then sighed in relief when I saw that everyone was still sleeping soundly.

“You can’t even speak English properly.”

“I learned several things on the internet. They said communication would pose no problem as long as I knew two phrases.”

“Go ahead, then.”

Mr. Stone-King, a proud native of Atlanta, Georgia, United States, opened his mouth.

“How are you. I’m fine, thank you. And you?”

“…You’re Korean, aren’t you, you bastard?”

He had a Hollywood face, but his skill and pronunciation were purely homegrown Korean.

As I shook my head in disbelief, the Skeleton King asked with a shocked expression,

“Is this king’s English truly that terrible?”

“Yeah. So let’s just say you’re half Korean. It’s not like anyone’s going to care about your background anyway.”

“Then I was adopted by a family in Atlanta, Georgia…”

“No, for fuck’s sake. Did you hide honey in Atlanta or something? Is every treasure in the world supposed to be there?”

“But it sounds impressive, does it not? I read on the internet that white men are popular with women all over the world. Besides, this king is handsome.”

“What good is that when you can’t even get it up?”

“…!”

Rendered speechless, the Skeleton King pointed at me with a trembling finger.

“How could you say something so cruel?”

“I can say worse, so stop talking nonsense. If you don’t want people finding out you’re a monster, wear this.”

The Skeleton King accepted the object I summoned from my Inventory and tilted his head, his anger forgotten.

“Vile human, what is this?”

“A gift from Magic Johnson. He said it took a while because he had to have it flown in from the United States on short notice.”

“That gracious human? A ring for me?”

The Skeleton King stared gravely at the ring I had given him.

“Is this perhaps what humans call a proposal?”

“What the hell are you talking about, you lunatic? It’s just a ring enchanted with translation magic.”

“Hmm. I appreciate the gift, but it looks rather crude. It does not sparkle like a diamond, either. It is unbefitting of a king’s dignity.”

“Magic Johnson commissioned a Grand Mage he knows to make it specially, so its performance is top-class. It’s probably worth whatever price they care to name.”

“Now that I look again, I can sense its noble dignity. It will uphold my royal authority nicely.”

“…”

What an irritating bastard.

There was no doubt about it. He had become far stronger—and far crazier—than he had been as the Skeleton Warlord.

Regardless, he slipped the ring onto his middle finger with a satisfied expression, then pulled a smartphone from the lining of his suit.

That, too, was an expensive, cutting-edge smartphone with a Magic Gem built into it, another gift from Magic Johnson.

“What are you doing?”

“This king must personally express his gratitude to the gracious human.”

“You’ve got better manners than I expected. Are you going to text him?”

“Vile human.”

“Huh?”

The Skeleton King looked at me as though I were pathetic.

“Who sends texts in this day and age? Naturally, one uses social media.”

"…Uh, sure."

"We already follow each other. I have also learned how to send direct messages."

I stared at the Skeleton King's phone, my mouth falling open.

Holy shit. It was real. An undead monster with a social media account. Did this app not even require identity verification?

But something else was even more surprising.

"…You have five thousand followers?"

"State the number accurately. It is 5,134. A record achieved in less than a week."

"What the hell? Is this fake?"

"Is being handsome not the greatest advantage? I merely used this king's face as my profile picture, and countless requests to follow one another came pouring in from around the world. Heh heh."

The Skeleton King answered with an arrogant look and began sending a message to Magic Johnson.

> └ Good human. I'm fine thank you. and you?

After checking the message, I let out a small sigh.

"Don't send messages to anyone else."

"Why not?"

"If I say don't, then don't, you bastard."

So much for Atlanta, Georgia.

Calling himself a native of Atlanta District, Georgia City, Gyeonggi Province, would have sounded more believable.

Apparently, even translation magic couldn't save English so painfully Korean that it made my head spin.

"At this rate, even the Akabutakchi tribe, who have preserved their traditions in the Amazon rainforest for hundreds of years, won't believe you're American."

"Hmm. I do not know exactly what you mean, but the oddly specific nature of it makes me even angrier."

"Just do as I say. If your identity gets exposed, it won't end with a little trouble."

No matter how good my public image was right now, if the Skeleton King's identity became known, we would clearly have to brace ourselves for considerable repercussions.

I turned my head.

"Isn't that right, Team Leader Choi?"

In the seat diagonally beside us, Team Leader Choi had been awake by himself for several minutes. He answered,

"I was already considering the matter of the Skeleton King—"

“Stone-King. Call me Mr. King.”

The Skeleton King cut him off firmly. Team Leader Choi stared at him for a moment, then continued with a sigh.

“In any case, we are considering every possibility regarding Mr. King’s future arrangements. For now, it would be best to avoid exposure to the press and other media.”

“I refuse. I will proudly reveal myself to the world.”

“Really? Team Leader Choi, what are the penalties for entering the country illegally?”

Team Leader Choi answered at once.

“Deportation, without question. He would also have to expect a fine or imprisonment.”

“What about entering illegally from the Demon Realm?”

“It has never happened before, but instead of the police, a large-scale raid team would be dispatched.”

“You heard him.”

The Skeleton King’s eyes swiveled back and forth in silence before he finally spoke.

“…It cannot be helped. The world is not yet prepared to accept this king, so I shall exercise restraint for a while.”

“That’s what you should do. Unless you want to spend the rest of your life lying low in my Inventory.”

“A-All right.”

The biggest headache was dealt with.

Now there was the second headache… and this one I had no choice but to face head-on.

Not because I lacked alternatives, but because doing so would help with my plans going forward.

It’s a pain, but it can’t be helped.

I quietly tapped the armrest, lost in thought, then abruptly spoke.

“What’s the atmosphere like back home right now?”

Team Leader Choi gave me a terse, emphatic answer.

“It’s insane.”

“…That bad?”

“When someone passes the judicial exam,[2074] banners go up in their neighborhood and at their alma mater, and the local newspaper runs a short article. More than fifteen hundred people pass that exam every year. How much more attention do you think you would receive, Mr. Jin Taekyung?”

[2074] Korea’s judicial exam was a competitive national examination for entry into the legal profession.

With that perfectly apt comparison, Team Leader Choi clicked in midair.

The holographic screen built into the seat filled with countless online articles.

[At Last, He Has Returned.]

[Who Is Jin Taekyung? Chairman Xiao Yang Bows His Head on Behalf of the Chinese People. The Reverent Farewell of S-Rank Hunters…]

[The Young Hero Who Fought to Rescue Survivors Until the Very End Finally Returns to the Arms of His Homeland.]

It wasn't just the Korean media. China, where the incident had taken place, and countries around the world were flooding the internet with article after article about my return and what I would do next.

I had known this was coming and expected it, but I still couldn't help gaping when I saw a photograph attached to an online article posted five minutes earlier.

"Wait. Are all those people actually human?"

"They aren't monsters, so they probably are."

"Holy shit…"

The photograph showed a crowd packed into Incheon Airport without so much as a gap between them.

Thousands? No, tens of thousands.

As I stared blankly at the screen, Team Leader Choi continued.

"Traffic throughout the surrounding area has come to a standstill, and a car parade is being prepared under military and police control."

"What? A car parade?"

"Did I not tell you?"

"You mentioned it in passing, so I thought you were joking. I mean… isn't this a bit much?"

Team Leader Choi shook his head firmly.

"It has to be this much. You are the new S-rank Hunter representing Korea."

"Even so, this is excessive. At this rate, the President will show up too."

"Ah, I really did fail to mention that."

"What?"

"He is coming. The Blue House[2075] contacted us first this morning. I meant to tell you on the plane, but I dozed off and forgot."

For a moment, my thoughts ground to a halt.

Tens of thousands of people waiting for me at Incheon Airport. Paralyzed roads and a spectacular car parade. And now the President was coming too.

I sat there speechless, then finally forced the words out.

"…Really? You're not joking?"

[2075]The Blue House was the office and residence of Korea's president.

“Yes. They want to shake your hand, stand with you at the photo line, and take a picture together.”

“Team Leader Choi, I don’t know anything about politics. If I get tangled up in something and it goes wrong, I’ll be completely screwed.”

“I know how you feel, Mr. Jin Taekyung. That is why I tried to turn them down politely, but they seemed quite determined. It was not easy.”

“You still should have refused. Even if I belong to Peace Guild, how could you make that decision on your own?”

No matter how much we trusted each other or how little time there had been, this was something he should have consulted me about.

At the sight of my rigid expression, Team Leader Choi lowered his head apologetically.

“I’m sorry. They offered several favorable conditions, including tax breaks, so I thought it would benefit you as well.”

“Forget that. Call them right now and tell them it’s off… Wait. Tax breaks?”

“Yes. You know the bounty that was placed on the Arch Lich. If the Chinese government pays it to you, then under Korean law, it would count as foreign-source income for a Korean resident…”

“Wait. So how much tax would I have to pay in total?”

“I cannot say for certain, but it would be several trillion won.[2076] The bounty alone is fifty trillion won.[2077] Even if we simplify things and assume only ten percent is deducted, it would still be an enormous amount. Of course, the amount left over would be much larger.”

“…That’s true.”

“Once again, I apologize for failing to get your approval. I will tell the Blue House[2078] that this is no longer happening.”

I nodded, my expression hard.

“Team Leader. This must never happen again.”

Right. I was about to get my hands on tens of trillions of won.[2079] Even if I paid every cent of tax I owed, I would still be incredibly wealthy.

No matter how insignificant the conditions they were offering might be, I couldn’t get involved with politicians just to save a little on taxes. That was something I needed to avoid.

[2076] A few or several trillion won is approximately $1.4–6.4 billion or €1.3–5.8 billion, taking the phrase as roughly two to nine trillion won.

[2077] Fifty trillion won is about $36 billion or €32 billion.

[2078] The Blue House was the office and residence of Korea’s president.

[2079] Tens of trillions of won is approximately $14–64 billion or €13–58 billion, taking the phrase as roughly twenty to ninety trillion won.

A few trillion won?[2080] *I can just pay it and be done with it.*

I cast my worries aside and leaned back against the soft seat.

Pop! Pop-pop-pop!

At Incheon Airport, hundreds of cameras flashed at once.

At the photo line set up under strict security, two men whose professions could not have been more different shook hands with broad smiles.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung. You’ve truly been through a lot.”

“Oh, not at all. You’ve been busy lately too, haven’t you, Mr. President?”

As the Skeleton King watched the scene, he thought,

What a vile human.

The thought applied just as much to Team Leader Choi, who was smiling contentedly as though everything had gone according to plan.

[2080] A few or several trillion won is approximately $1.4–6.4 billion or €1.3–5.8 billion, taking the phrase as roughly two to nine trillion won.

Chapter 440

The day Jin Taekyung's private jet landed at Incheon International Airport, cameras from around the world turned toward Korea.

Countless flashes erupted without pause, bright enough to make people forget the sun was already setting. Despite the midwinter cold, hundreds of thousands packed the surrounding area and greeted the returning hero with thunderous cheers.

And at the center of it all stood one man, staring blankly at the welcome that had far exceeded anything he'd imagined.

"…What the hell is all this, goddammit?"

His voice was no louder than an ant's, but the world's media outlets had brought their best equipment. They didn't miss the young hero's offhand remark.

"What the sibu-leol?"[2081]

"Que veut-elle dire par là?"

"Was meint sie damit?"

Korean profanity was famously diverse—so much so that even translation devices struggled with it.

The Western reporters hesitated, unable to grasp the full-bodied meaning of *sibu-leol*[2082], but the Korean reporters, who had mastered all manner of wildly inventive curses since their school days, moved like lightning.

"An article! Get it online now! We have to be first!"

"W-With this?"

"You idiot, don't you know that everything Jin Taekyung does is breaking news right now? Stop wasting time. Get a shot of his mouth as he swears, grab the audio, and upload it immediately!"

"Yes, Senior! But, Senior… won't this cause trouble?"

"Trouble? What trouble?"

"If it looks like we're attacking Jin Taekyung, there could be a backlash. You know, something like *Jin Taekyung Profanity Controversy*…"

The veteran reporter scowled at his junior.

Was that kid in his second year now, or his third? After working in the field this long, he should've learned to think, but he was still hopelessly slow on the uptake.

The veteran barely held back a curse when he remembered that the idiot in front of him was the bureau chief's nephew.

"Hey. Reporter Hong."

"Yes."

[2081] *Sibu-leol* is a Korean profanity, roughly equivalent to "fuck."

[2082] *Sibu-leol* is a Korean profanity, roughly equivalent to "fuck."

"Jin Taekyung is allowed to swear."

"What?"

"When a politician or celebrity swears in public in this country, they become the worst person alive. But when Jin Taekyung does it, people nearly die of happiness. Understand?"

"Yes, yes, Senior!"

Only then did the junior nod. The veteran let out a deep sigh and looked at his smartphone.

The chatroom for the live stream currently airing on iTube, the world's largest video-sharing website, was already going berserk.

> ㄴ □□□□□□□□□□□□□ Sibu-leol.
>
> ㄴ Lord Fuck… *he* is back.
>
> ㄴ Lord Balls too. I saw him bet his balls on the Chinese news earlier and laughed my ass off, seriously lmao.
>
> ㄴ King Taekyung. The bastard who pulled off an incredible achievement, told every interview to fuck off, and wrapped up his official press conference in thirty minutes…
>
> ㄴ And yet fought like hell to rescue the survivors until the very end…
>
> ㄴ The bastard who bet his balls instead of money on a Chinese state-run broadcast watched by at least ten million people…
>
> ㄴ The bastard who says *sibu-leol* in front of the entire world…
>
> ㄴ King Taekyung. Infinitely warmhearted, but completely insane…
>
> ㄴ □□□□□□ Is he even a Hunter, or is he some kind of eccentric?
>
> ㄴ Nope, he's Lord Sibu-leol.
>
> ㄴ □□□□□□□□□□ Lord Sibu-leol is pretty good.
>
> ㄴ □□□□□□□□ Actually, didn't King Taekyung say something about this in an earlier interview? He asked people to stop calling him Lord Fuck.
>
> ㄴ Really? Got it, hyung![2083] From today on, I'll call him Lord Sibu-leol!
>
> ㄴ He doesn't like Lord Fuck? Then we have to call him Lord Sibu-leol from now on lmao.
>
> ㄴ Lord Fuck + Lord Balls = Lord Sibu-leol.
>
> ㄴ Look at that buildup lmao. At this point, was it intentional?
>
> ㄴ Hello, everyone. What do you think about the fact that Mr. Jin is a descendant of Jin Chui, a general of the Ming dynasty? China is a great and powerful country, so if he were to become a naturalized citizen, it would be an even better opportunity for him. Oh, and for the record, I'm Korean.

[2083] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance. *Hyungs* is its plural.

> ㄴ ??????
>
> ㄴ Why are you suddenly dumping jajang[2084] sauce in here…
>
> ㄴ Take care on your way home, Mr. Wang.
>
> ㄴ If that bastard is Korean, then I'm an Asgardian. I drank beer with Thor in Valhalla yesterday.
>
> ㄴ Heh, Chinese as expected. You give yourself away immediately because you're an idiot wwwww. Of course, Jin Taekyung is an idiot too. I'm Korean as well, but I think it's a nuisance to everyone when he uses such vulgar language at an official event like today. At the very least, there's something to learn from our neighboring country Japan when it comes to national character.
>
> ㄴ ????
>
> ㄴ Jajang[2085] sauce wasn't enough, so now you're dumping wasabi on us too…
>
> ㄴ "Heh" lmao. You sound like some Japanese right-winger trembling with rage at King Taekyung. Why are you so stupid?
>
> ㄴ ??? : Magdonaldo. Ssankyu![2086]
>
> ㄴ Please watch your own country's broadcasts. Stop coming to Korea's official channel and pretending to be Korean.
>
> ㄴ Wwwww, it's hilarious how hard you're denying reality. I really am Korean.
>
> ㄴ Where do you live?
>
> ㄴ Seoul City, Busan District.[2087]
>
> ㄴ Ha…
>
> ㄴ There's a reason people call this place Hell Joseon.[2088] What is this, left Azure Dragon and right White Tiger?[2089] We've got left jajang[2090] and right wasabi.
>
> ㄴ There's even a Devil Fruit user up north.[2091]
>
> ㄴ ??? : Uncle-in-law, uncle-in-law, total barrage![2092]

[2084] *Jajang* is the black-bean sauce used in Korean-style Chinese noodles. Here it stands for the Chinese commenter, just as wasabi stands for the Japanese commenter.

[2085] *Jajang* is the black-bean sauce used in Korean-style Chinese noodles. Here it stands for the Chinese commenter, just as wasabi stands for the Japanese commenter.

[2086] "Magdonaldo" and "Ssankyu" imitate Japanese pronunciations of "McDonald's" and "thank you."

[2087] Seoul and Busan are separate cities; Busan is not a district of Seoul.

[2088] "Hell Joseon" is a cynical nickname for South Korea, comparing modern society to the rigid and oppressive Joseon era.

[2089] The Azure Dragon and White Tiger are traditional symbols associated with the east and west, respectively.

[2090] *Jajang* is the black-bean sauce used in Korean-style Chinese noodles. Here it stands for the Chinese commenter, just as wasabi stands for the Japanese commenter.

[2091] Devil Fruits grant supernatural powers in the manga *One Piece*. "Up north" refers to North Korea.

> ㄴ Don’t get baited by weirdos. Watch the broadcast. The car parade is about to start.
>
> ㄴ It really is. Don’t get angry over pointless stuff, hyungs.[2093] Let’s just watch King Taekyung.

Broadcast networks, cable channels, and general programming channels were all showing the scene. On top of that, viewers around the world were watching through iTube’s live stream.

With untold numbers watching, the massive limousine bus carrying Jin Taekyung and his companions began to move.

The cheers grew louder, flashes burst everywhere, and drones filled the sky overhead, painting patterns across the night.

> ㄴ Wow, this is insane. There are so many people that the cameras can’t even fit them all in the frame □□;[2094]
>
> ㄴ This is bigger than the Olympics. How many drones are there, anyway?
>
> ㄴ A lot, I guess?
>
> ㄴ I know that much…
>
> ㄴ I got goose bumps the moment the bus started moving. My chest actually swelled up. Is this for real?

The limousine bus carrying Jin Taekyung and his companions moved at ten kilometers per hour[2095] through a wall of people.

Brilliant fireworks exploded without pause, and flower petals scattered by the crowd whirled through the air on the wind.

At first, Jin Taekyung watched the scene with an awkwardly stiff expression. Before long, however, he smiled and waved at the crowd.

They’re people who like me.

Six months ago, Jin Taekyung had been no more than a grain of sand on a beach.

An F-rank Hunter who could be found anywhere, ignored by everyone and swept away whenever a wave rolled in.

He had never once imagined that a day like this would come.

All I ever dreamed of was retiring without dying…

[2092] This twists the name of an attack from *One Piece* into a reference to an uncle by marriage, alluding to the execution of North Korean leader Kim Jong-un’s uncle by marriage.

[2093] *Hyung* is a term a man uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance. *Hyungs* is its plural.

[2094] □□ represents trembling and is used online to express shock or awe.

[2095] Ten kilometers per hour is about 6.2 mph.

He had gained so much. He'd been forced to walk a thorny path with death on every side, but the fruit hanging along the way had been sweet. Power beyond his wildest imagination, enormous wealth, and even fame.

And…

"You've worked hard, my son."

"I'm really proud of you too, Mr. Jin Taekyung, but these flashes are so bright I can barely see your face. How long are those reporters planning to keep this up?"

His family, who had always been with him.

His mother's warm hand stroking his back made his throat tighten, while the sight of his sister scrunching up her face against the flashes drew a quiet laugh from him.

"Mom worked harder than I did. You too, Sis."

"I know. Mom and Oppa[2096] worked harder."

"I thought you were barely human, but you do have a shred of conscience after all."

"Wow, listen to him."

"Smile, you idiot. Do you have any idea how many cameras are filming us right now?"

With that joking remark, Jin Taekyung pulled them both into a hug. Then he met a pair of eyes watching him from behind his family.

"You've truly been through a lot, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"You too, Team Leader Choi. I'm just a big, dumb brute. Without you, I really would've had a hard time."

"I only did what I had to do. And I'll continue to do the same."

"You're saying something scary with a smile."

"You know this isn't the end."

He knew.

That was why his resolve hardened even further.

Jin Taekyung had made it this far across a perilous field of thorns. He couldn't allow his precious family and friends to walk the same path.

Even if his feet became covered in blood and he collapsed from the pain, he would protect them from the threats drawing ever closer.

Sometimes they would join forces. And even if it meant sacrificing himself…

"I'll be counting on you for a long time to come."

Team Leader Choi stared at the hand Jin Taekyung held out. Then a deep dimple appeared beside his mouth.

"Yes. Always."

[2096] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

Just as the two firmly clasped hands, a grumbling voice rang out inside Jin Taekyung's head.

You're all having a grand old time.

Are you still sulking?

Who is sulking?! Does this body, reborn as a great king, look as though it would feel such a petty human emotion?

You're definitely sulking.

I am not!

The attention seeker—no, the Skeleton King—who had been forced by circumstances to hide in the Inventory had been sulking bitterly for quite a while.

Jin Taekyung smiled faintly and spoke inwardly.

Hey.

Do not speak to me!

Thanks for everything so far. I'm counting on you from here on out, too.

H-Hmm.

The Skeleton King cleared his throat and continued hesitantly.

Since you put it that way, I shall consider it.

Consider what?

Staying with you, you vile human.

Oh, you don't need to consider that.

What?

You're joining Peace Guild no matter what. I've already had the contract drawn up, so go put your thumbprint on it. No, wait. Your fingerprints won't show up in a records check, so I guess you'll have to stamp it with your skull.

What is this?! Is this not a free and democratic country?!

Nope. I'm going to work you like a slave and suck out every last drop, right down to your marrow.

Release this body immediately! Turn the car around!

Unable to hold it in any longer, Jin Taekyung burst out laughing and leaned toward the driver's seat.

"Could we head straight to the next destination?"

"Pardon?"

The startled driver stammered out a reply.

"That's different from the instructions we received beforehand."

"Can't we?"

"I'm sorry, but we can't."

"We really can't?"

"I'm afraid not…"

“Seriously, truly, we can’t?”

The driver answered in a voice halfway to surrender.

“…I think we might be able to.”

“Then please take us to Peace Guild’s guild house.”

The driver relayed the request to his superior. After it passed through several levels of reporting, the higher-ups were bewildered but readily agreed.

And the roughly three thousand drones followed the seemingly endless car parade.

The limousine bus carrying Jin Taekyung and his companions eventually stopped in front of Peace Guild’s guild house.

Every moment of their meeting with the Guild members waiting there was captured on camera and broadcast around the world.

Even after midnight passed and the long-awaited Christmas Eve arrived, the fervor showed no sign of dying down.

If anything, people seemed to compete to feed fresh wood and wind to the fading flames.

The name Jin Taekyung was everywhere, and for someone still suffering from severe aftereffects, it was unbearable torment.

“This morning, the United States’ S-rank Hunter Magic Johnson announced through his official social-media account that he is pursuing some kind of agreement with Peace Guild—”

Bang!

The announcer’s face vanished from the holographic television. The man who had smashed the machine screamed.

“Jin Taekyung, Jin Taekyung, Jin Taekyung!”

Bang! Crash!

His eyes were bloodshot. Powerful qi shot from his wildly swinging fists, smashing everything around him and reducing it to dust.

That name was more hateful than any other.

At the same time, it belonged to the man who had shown him a fear he could never forget.

“Aaaaaaaagh!”

Just as Go Jun howled amid the devastated room, a faint sound of movement reached him, followed by a cautious voice.

“T-Team Leader.”

Chapter 441

"T-Team Leader. May I come in for a moment?"

The voice was taut with tension.

Go Jun glared at the door with bloodshot eyes and thrust out a hand.

Crack!

A tremendous force tore through the air, ripping apart the iron door and crumpling it like a sheet of paper.

The security-team employee who witnessed the incredible sight from a few feet away swallowed a startled breath.

"Gasp."

"I told you not to let anyone approach."

The moment he met Go Jun's blazing red eyes, a chill ran down his spine.

He had heard his colleagues talk about the extreme change in their direct superior, who had always been as precise and cold as a machine. But facing him like this, the team member's voice trembled with fear despite himself.

"I-It's just that… there's something I need to report…"

"Put it off."

His voice was low, as though dragged up from the depths of an abyss.

The team member would have loved to do exactly that. But if it had been anything trivial, they would never have drawn lots to decide who had to deliver the report.

He swallowed hard and summoned his courage.

"The head of the investigation team contacted us urgently. He said they found a strange object they couldn't identify…"

Go Jun, who had been about to turn away, came to an abrupt stop.

"A strange object?"

"Yes, Team Leader."

"Could it be—"

"No, sir."

Afraid Go Jun's anger might turn on him, the team member hurriedly continued.

"We checked. None of the late Vice Guild Master's belongings have been found yet."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. We're constantly monitoring the team members dispatched to the site in case they try to pocket anything. There's no doubt."

"And?"

"Pardon?"

"There's only one report I need from those bastards. A report saying they found what I need."

Go Jun's eyes darkened.

Even now, with the Crown Prince Party—closely tied to Ares Guild—on the decline, the Guild's influence and power remained intact.

The person in charge could change. The government could be replaced. But the greed that lived in every human heart would never disappear.

Even the straightest bamboo bent beneath enough weight. Go Jun had created that weight with tens of billions of won.[2097]

The head of the investigation team managing the city that had once been the Arch Lich's stronghold, along with the senior officials under him, had proved no different.

"Tell those bastards to find it, no matter what it takes. Until then, I don't want to hear from them again."

There was no such thing as a favor in this world without a price. Go Jun had bought them with a fortune, and if they failed to deliver what he wanted, he intended to retaliate accordingly.

That was how important the object was.

Not merely because it was a keepsake of the Master he had followed like a father. It could also become a powerful weapon—one capable of driving someone into a corner with no escape.

A holographic recorder.

Lee Jungryong had been the true master of the immensely influential Ares Guild. In case the unexpected ever happened, he had always carried a miniature holographic recorder on his person.

The day he died at Jin Taekyung's hands had been no exception.

All the evidence is in there. If I can find it, then afterward…

At that moment, the fire in Go Jun's eyes wavered violently.

Afterward… what am I supposed to do?

Before he knew it, the face of one man—someone he hated beyond measure and feared even more—flashed before his eyes.

…Jin Taekyung.

Merely thinking the name made his heart plummet and his hands and feet tremble.

The indifferent gaze that had looked down at him beneath the faint moonlight and the dry voice that had accompanied it clouded his eyes and ears like an apparition.

I'll say this one last time.

[2097] Tens of billions of won is roughly ₩20–90 billion: about $14–64 million or €13–58 million.

The voice had burrowed into Go Jun's ears while he screamed in unimaginable agony.

Let it end with Lee Jungryong. Hide your teeth and put away your claws. If you do that… nothing will happen.

Every bone in his body had been crushed like matchsticks, and his raw flesh had been torn away as though wrung from his body. Without even getting the chance to wield his weapon properly, he had been left thrashing in an endless swamp of pain.

Lee Jungryong had been an insurmountable wall and a Master Go Jun revered.

Jin Taekyung was something no one had ever seen before.

No. He was like…

"A monster."

The single word that escaped Go Jun without his realizing it was steeped in all the emotions and fear he felt.

Then he came to his senses and understood.

His hatred for Jin Taekyung was nothing compared to his terror.

Jin Taekyung's existence was fear itself, branded forever into Go Jun's soul like a mark burned into flesh. At the same time, it was another name for the perfect helplessness he had felt for the first time in his life.

"T-Team Leader?"

Go Jun did not answer. Teeth clenched, he lowered his head and stared at his trembling hands.

What the fuck is this…

Crunch.

He bit his lip until it bled, then raised his head. Ignoring the team member's bewildered stare at the sight of his frightened superior, he spoke.

"Tell the head of the investigation team to bring me that damned strange object. I don't know what it is, but I should at least see it for myself."

"But a moment ago, you said—Ah, understood."

Realizing his mistake, the team member hurriedly bowed and left the room.

Only after walking a considerable distance down the corridor did he finally release the breath he had been holding. He gestured to the hotel employees waiting nearby.

"Wait here for a while. Go in once he's calmed down. And the new room is ready, right?"

The Chinese hotel employees nodded calmly.

This was not the first time Go Jun had gone on a rampage. It had already happened several times over the past week.

But what did that matter?

Until a few days ago, the hotel had belonged to a local notable in Sichuan Province. Once Ares Guild bought it, the Koreans before them became their new employers.

And excellent employers they were, lavishing the staff with extra pay in exchange for their silence.

“I’m tired of repeating myself. We all know the situation, so let’s do our jobs properly.”

The team member tossed them a thick envelope, wiped the sweat from his brow, and walked away.

Being unable to leave this godforsaken land of China was bad enough. What troubled him even more was the unstable condition of the man poised to succeed Lee Jungryong as the new captain of Ares Guild.

Could that rumor really have been true?

He recalled the story quietly circulating within the security team.

And the unease stirring within him.

The treatment is incredible, but if Team Leader stays like that from now on…

There would be no problem if Go Jun remained the head of security. The enormous warship called the Ares Guild was not so fragile that one mistake by a helmsman could make it capsize.

But if the man at the helm became its new captain, that was a different story.

Damn it. I’ve never had to worry about this before.

The team member muttered to himself and pulled a smartphone from inside his suit jacket. It was a work phone that left no records and could not be traced.

After a long series of rings, someone answered.

“Ah, Mr. Park. I’ve been waiting for your call.”

“I’ll get straight to the point. Our team leader wants to see the object you mentioned for himself.”

“In person?”

“Yes. In person. Our team leader wants to avoid public attention as much as possible right now, so you understand what I’m saying, don’t you?”

The head of the investigation team cleared his throat on the other end of the call.

“Ahem. That may be difficult. Since this is the Arch Lich’s former stronghold, there are foreign personnel dispatched by the United Nations as well, and security is tighter than you might think…”

“Name your price. But there can’t be a single mistake.”

A short while later, the team member ended the call and clicked his tongue.

“Greedy bastards. Money is all they care about. Then again, I guess that works in our favor.”

The world did not change easily. Before overwhelming wealth and power, the word *impossible* lost all meaning.

Since joining Ares Guild's security team, he had witnessed the impossible being made possible countless times.

And that fortresslike power would naturally be inherited by one man.

Team Leader Go Jun.

The new captain of Ares Guild.

He himself was merely one of countless rowers, but Go Jun was different. As his thoughts reached that point, he found himself wondering about the one man Go Jun feared so much.

Jin Taekyung.

No one could silence people completely.

The rumor had begun when three Hunters who had secretly left with Go Jun one day a week earlier started talking.

For now, only a tiny handful within the security team—Go Jun's closest associates—knew the truth. But soon enough, it would spread like an epidemic.

If it's true… Haa. Things have gotten seriously complicated.

The team member took a deep breath and focused.

From now on, he would have countless decisions to agonize over. Should he stay aboard his current ship or leave for another?

If he wanted to avoid becoming anyone's enemy, his only choice was to leave the field entirely.

I need to keep my head on straight. Yeah.

Right now, his first priority was retrieving the object the head of the investigation team had smuggled out.

As he headed toward the agreed meeting place, he suddenly found himself envying Jin Taekyung.

Damn. If I had fifty trillion won[2098] like that bastard, I'd move straight to Europe and live like royalty.

He was wealthy himself and owned several buildings, but human greed was not so easily satisfied.

Once someone owned an expensive foreign car, they wanted a luxury yacht and a helicopter. Then they wanted a private jet of their own.

The team member smacked his lips in envy.

I wonder what Jin Taekyung is doing right now. Throwing a party on a luxury yacht with Playboy models?

Well-tanned bronze muscles rippled beneath the blazing sunlight.

[2098] Fifty trillion won is about $36 billion or €32 billion.

Their identity was that of beautiful model women from around the world who had gathered to enjoy a yacht party with me…

“One, two!”

“Heave-ho!”

…or not.

They belonged to the river bandits of the Water Dragon Stronghold.

I watched the musclebound monsters bustling around the deck with a mournful gaze.

A yacht party, my ass.

I had only ever seen that kind of thing online, and I intended to keep it that way.

Reality wasn’t a boat party with beautiful women. It was staring out at the Yangtze from a deck packed with musclebound river bandits doing boat PT.[2099]

No. There was one more thing.

Whoosh!

I had to dodge the finger flicks our boisterous Old Master, Fire King Jeok Cheongang, sent flying whenever he got bored.

“Well, look at you. Dodging, are we?”

“…Isn’t dodging them the whole point of this training? You said I needed to maintain a mind like a clear mirror and still water while heightening my senses so I could get used to my Middle Dantian.”

Jeok Cheongang answered without a shred of shame.

“That one was meant to hit you. How dare you look away during training?”

“I was looking away with both eyes.”

“Why, you little… Want me to gouge them out for you?”

Eyes blazing, Jeok Cheongang crooked his fingers like claws and continued.

“Do you think this training is easy? Even when you concentrate fully, you can barely dodge them.”

“Fine, fine. I understand. I said I understand.”

Grumbling, I closed my eyes.

Then, a moment later, I quietly opened them again.

“But…”

“What?”

“Didn’t I just dodge that perfectly even while looking away?”

“Oh. You did, didn’t you?”

“…?”

“…?”

“…!”

[2099] PT means personal training, a common abbreviation in Korean gym usage.

"…!"

What the hell was this?

Jeok Cheongang pressed his lips tightly together beneath my incredulous stare, then abruptly exploded.

"Not like that! Do it like that brat! Like him!"

He pointed at a young man sitting cross-legged without so much as twitching.

For some reason, Cheongpung had been forced to join me in training.

"Look at that brat. He may be a little strange most of the time, but when it matters, he does everything perfectly. His posture hasn't wavered, and his breathing remains long, light, and steady. An unwavering mind and posture, no matter what happens around him. That is what it means to possess a mind like a clear mirror and still water."

After showering Cheongpung with praise without pausing for breath, Jeok Cheongang pointed at him again.

"Watch carefully how he dodges. Now, when I send a finger flick…"

Whoosh! Thud!

The finger flick struck Cheongpung squarely in the temple, and his eyes flew open.

He looked around through eyes still heavy with sleep, then rubbed his head when the pain finally seemed to register.

"Ow. That hurts…"

Then he returned to dreamland faster than light.

I stared at Jeok Cheongang.

"Clear as a mirror? What?"

"A clear mirror… Forget it. You and that brat both. To hell with all of it!"

The Yangtze was peaceful today, too.

Chapter 442

Like the majestic waters of the Yangtze, time flowed slowly but steadily onward.

It was late afternoon on the fourth day since we had left Sichuan by Murim reckoning. As I sat on the deck, a familiar presence approached.

“What are you doing?”

I knew who it was just from his footsteps.

Without taking my eyes off the Yangtze, I answered, “What does it look like I’m doing?”

Hyuk Mujin limped over and answered without hesitation.

“Looks like you’re just sitting there.”

“I’m thinking.”

“About what?”

“The peace of Murim.”

After a brief silence, hearty laughter burst out.

“Puhaha! That’s the funniest joke I’ve heard all year. That’s our Captain.”

“No. Forget it. I just thought of something else.”

“What?”

“There’s a certain bastard who always takes everything I say for dog shit. But maybe because he’s been feeling better lately, he doesn’t seem able to control his mouth. So I’m wondering whether I should beat him a few times. What do you think?”

Hyuk Mujin considered the question for a moment.

“It isn’t the person I’m thinking of, is it?”

“Probably.”

“Who is it?”

“Someone named Hyuk Mujin.”

“…”

“Be quiet unless you want another taste of the Yangtze.”

Hyuk Mujin nodded frantically, practically having a seizure.

“Please, anything but that…!”

A few days earlier, I had sentenced him to a Yangtze dunking and immediately logged out, leaving him to spend an entire shichen[2100] sightseeing at the Yangtze Aquarium.

The moment Mungyeong’s superb medical skills had restored him to reasonable health, he had even cast a fishing line, declaring that he would catch every last bastard that had bitten his nose and slice them into sashimi.

[2100] A shichen is a traditional time period of approximately two hours.

“Fine, calm down. Why are you here?”

“Huh?”

“I’m asking what you want. There must be a reason.”

Hyuk Mujin asked in a wounded voice, “Do I really need a reason to come see you? Between us?”

“If you don’t have one, you get a taste of the Yangtze.”

“I have one! I do!”

“Then spit it out.”

“This might just be me, but…”

Hyuk Mujin hesitated before continuing.

“Is something bothering you lately?”

“Why?”

“No reason. It’s just that whenever I look at you these days, you seem to have a lot on your mind.”

“Me?”

“Yes. And, well… To be honest, not much has happened lately compared to before. But somehow, you’re the only one who seems tired and busy. I guess that’s the best way to put it.”

“Hmm…”

“You seem to be sleeping more often, too.”

When had this bastard gotten so perceptive?

Under my strange gaze, Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head.

“Well, that’s just the impression I got. Am I wrong?”

“Yeah. You are.”

Naturally, my answer was a lie. Hyuk Mujin’s guess was exactly right.

Since first setting foot in Murim, I had never traveled between the two worlds as often as I had lately.

Looking back, though, every one of those trips was my own choice.

Sometimes a Quest had blocked the Logout function, but most of the time, I had made the decision myself.

If I had crossed over to the other world and spent time there while walking across thin ice, my tension would have collapsed, and I would have been unable to overcome the crisis.

But recently, the situation had changed.

Both the modern world and Murim have made it over a mountain.

How long had it been since both worlds had fallen quiet at the same time?

Murim had been a minefield of constant upheaval from the very beginning. Even the relatively peaceful modern world had started growing turbulent after my conflict with Lee Jungryong.

For the first time in ages—no, for the first time since I had obtained the System—I had found peace in both worlds.

But deep down, I had a suspicion bordering on certainty.

This peace would not last long.

The calm before the storm. The brief peace I had been given was like the stillness of the night before a storm broke.

That was why I was busily traveling between the two worlds, preparing for the storm soon to come. It was also why, even with the breathtaking scenery of the Yangtze spread out before me, I was still hunched over a mystery that refused to yield.

What the hell is this?

I stared at the paper in my hand.

The not particularly high-quality xuan paper[2101] was covered with strange patterns and symbols I had drawn myself.

There were all kinds of them, each subtly different in shape. They looked like some mysterious script out of a detective novel.

No. I almost wished that were all they were. Then I wouldn't have to worry so much.

"What's that?"

"A storm."

"Huh?"

"Honestly, I don't really know either."

Or perhaps I already knew and simply didn't want to believe it.

These patterns and symbols were the sole point of overlap between two worlds with different flows of time, different histories, and different cultures.

In the modern world, they had been found in the Arch Lich's magic circle. In Murim, they had appeared in Dark Heaven's formations.

And now, deep in my heart, I was turning over a single word.

Black magic.

I had no idea how bizarre or far-ranging Murim's demonic, heterodox arts—commonly called demonic martial arts—could be.

But the more I looked back on everything I had personally seen and experienced, the more it resembled black magic.

The Blood Lord. The Western Heaven Demon Lord. Even the formation we found in the cave.

[2101] Xuan paper is a traditional paper used for Chinese calligraphy and painting.

The Blood Lord's recovery after being struck by Jeok Cheongang's Dance of the Fire God and Demon had resembled a Troll's regeneration more than anything human. The Lord of Heaven, whom the Western Heaven Demon Lord worshiped so fervently, had appeared before me through the body of a subordinate who was already dead.

On top of that, the formations used by the black-robed men who had followed their respective leaders and drenched Shaolin and Sichuan in blood were astonishingly similar to what the modern world called Warp Gates.

At this point, it would be stranger not to suspect anything.

At the same time… the fact that I did not want to believe it easily was my reality.

Black magic in Murim.

This was more serious than having a female friend I secretly had a crush on use the bathroom at my house, only to find the toilet seat left up afterward.

Where did it come from? How? Why?

My head was full of question marks. An investigation was already underway in the modern world, but I felt as though I were wandering through endless fog.

More frightening still was the unknown something lurking beyond that fog, yet to reveal itself.

If all my fears turned out to be true, then…

"What are you staring at so intently?"

The voice shattered my deep thoughts and brought me back to reality. I frowned.

Not because my train of thought had been interrupted, but because of the rancid stench assaulting my nose.

Suppressing an instinctive gag, I asked, "You haven't washed again, have you?"

Gung Gibang, who had subtly pressed his butt against the spot beside me, nodded.

"It's only natural for a beggar not to wash. Is there a problem?"

Hyuk Mujin opened his mouth with a queasy expression.

"Young Hero Gung, are you some kind of poison man? The moment you came within three jang,[2102] my head started spinning and I began dry-heaving."

"A Beggars' Sect disciple washes only three times in his life: when he is born, when he joins the Beggars' Sect, and when he dies."

I turned to Gung Gibang, who was spouting this bullshit.

"Then go dunk yourself in the river before I kill you right now. Since you're going in anyway, scrub off some of that grime while you're at it."

"No. I hate water. Especially after that day."

Ah. Right. He was another victim of the Yangtze dunking.

[2102] A jang is a traditional Korean length of approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft); three jang is approximately 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

Gung Gibang answered with a grave expression, then glanced at the paper in my hand.

"Were you looking at that again?"

"Again? Young Hero Gung, you knew about it?"

At Hyuk Mujin's question, Gung Gibang nodded.

"Of course. A few days ago, he suddenly told me to follow him and showed it to me. Asked if I'd ever seen it anywhere before. Naturally, I told him I'd never seen anything like it in my life."

"Captain, how could you discriminate against me like this?"

I gave the wounded Hyuk Mujin a warm smile.

"Easily."

"…"

"I showed it to him because he's the Successor Beggar. I thought he might know something. Satisfied?"

Having found something to tease Hyuk Mujin about, Gung Gibang snickered.

"He showed it to Mungyeong, too."

"Hey, that was…"

I opened my mouth, but I couldn't exactly reveal Mungyeong's identity, so I closed it again.

It wasn't only because Mungyeong was watching us from several jang[2103] away while pointedly stroking a large acupuncture needle.

Seriously.

"See that, you Hyuk bastard? That's where you stand. Not in his heart, but in his little toe—urk!"

Grab. Whoosh!

Listening to him was getting so irritating that my ears hurt. I grabbed Gung Gibang by the collar and hurled him over the railing.

He flailed in midair, then plunged into the river with a short scream.

Splash!

He must have struck the water fairly hard, because the spray reached the ship's railing.

The next moment, Cheongpung, who had been giggling at the surprise entertainment, suddenly screamed.

"No! Mimi!"

What now?

I peered more closely to see what had happened, then doubted my eyes.

[2103] A jang is a traditional Korean length of approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft); three jang is approximately 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

A horned snake, pure white from head to tail, was thrashing wildly as it swam toward us for dear life.

The clear waters of the Yangtze were turning pitch-black around Gung Gibang, while several fish that had been swimming peacefully nearby floated belly-up.

"…What the fuck?"

Even the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake was reacting like that. Had Hyuk Mujin been right? Was Gung Gibang really some kind of poison man?

The river bandits who witnessed this absurd case of water pollution unfold in real time began seriously debating whether Gung Gibang belonged to the Beggars' Sect or the Sichuan Tang Clan.

I let out a deep sigh and gestured to them.

"Get him out quickly. If you want to keep working as river bandits on the Yangtze."

Realizing that their home waters were under threat, the river bandits sprang into action.

After that, I continued traveling between the modern world and Murim once or several times a day, handling everything I needed to do while continuing my investigation.

News that my Peace Guild and the Wizard Guild led by Magic Johnson had entered into some kind of agreement became a major topic of conversation among Hunters around the world.

But for ordinary people, the bigger story was still me—the individual named Jin Taekyung.

> World Hunter Association: "Jin Taekyung is an undeniable S-rank Hunter and a hero who has saved countless lives. The fact that he is still classified as an A-rank Hunter is absurd." He is expected to visit the Association headquarters for a brief test, after which he will be issued an S-rank Hunter license. The World Hunter Association sends Jin Taekyung a fervent invitation!

> Breaking News: Jin Taekyung flatly rejects the Association's offer. "Circumstances make it difficult for me to go right now. I'll stop by when I have time." World Hunter Association left bewildered.

> World Hunter Association issues new statement: “This is unprecedented. S-rank Hunter testing and licensing have always been conducted at Association headquarters.”

> Jin Taekyung: “I didn’t say I wouldn’t take the test. I said I’d go later. I can take it in Korea, so what’s the problem? Instead of arguing about precedent, let’s try being efficient.”

> A senior Hunter Association official, wounded in his pride, issues a threat: “Then we cannot issue you an S-rank Hunter license.”

> Urgent Breaking News: Brief social-media post reads, “Then don’t. Who the hell do you think you are, threatening me? Fucking hell.” Account confirmed to be Jin Taekyung’s official social-media account… Public reaction? “That was unbelievably satisfying.” “More refreshing than the soda we drank during the Thousand-Ri March.”[2104]

> World Hunter Association: “The official’s statement was a personal slip and does not represent the organization’s position. We apologize.” Final decision made to dispatch a testing team to Korea for Jin Taekyung.

> Japanese Prime Minister Koizumi: “Jin Taekyung is fun, cool, and sexy. I will make certain that he becomes a naturalized Japanese citizen. Because that is my ‘promise’…”

Leaving behind the countless incidents and remarks surrounding me, I returned to Murim.

And then…

“I can finally breathe again. Damn Yangtze.”

With Jeok Cheongang’s refreshing remark ringing out, the bow of the swift ship finally entered Hubei Province after nearly ten days of sailing.

[2104] The Thousand-Ri March refers to a long-distance Korean military march. A thousand Korean ri is approximately 393 km (244 mi).

Chapter 443

Ten days of sailing had been anything but easy.

We weren't aboard some massive cruise ship. We'd been stuck on a wooden vessel, shuttling between musty cabins and damp decks. Ports? Our schedule was so tight that we'd kept our eyes ahead and sailed straight on.

Under the circumstances, even Jeok Cheongang—and the river bandits who called the Yangtze their home turf—brightened.

Of course, one person was happier than all the rest.

"Ohhh, finally…"

Mu Song, who had been forced to volunteer his talents all the way to Hubei Province, trembled with emotion.

He had been sunk in grief ever since one of his swift ships sank, but now, as if he had forgotten every hardship he'd suffered along the way, he shouted in a powerful voice.

"Drop anchor! Hurry up so we can leave this damn…!"

Jeok Cheongang, who had been nodding in satisfaction, turned toward him.

"This damn what?"

Mu Song realized he had let his true feelings slip and shook his head at tremendous speed.

"N-no, sir. I meant the Yangtze."

"Of course you meant the Yangtze. That's what this old man meant, too."

"…"

"Unless you were calling *us* damnable?"

"W-why would I ever do that?"

It certainly looked like he would.

While Mu Song broke out in a cold sweat beneath Jeok Cheongang's narrowed gaze, the river bandits sensed their leader's peril and sprang into action.

The swift ships gradually slowed, lined up along the pier, and dropped anchor. A murmur rose from the people gathered near the harbor.

"That flag…"

"The Yangtze River Channel League. It's the Yangtze River Channel League!"

"What does it say underneath? Water Dragon Stronghold? Never heard of it."

"It's a river stronghold based in Sichuan. Water Dragon Stronghold is led by Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song, the Seafaring King's second Disciple."

"Now that you mention it, I think I've heard of them. But why are those bastards in Hubei when they're supposed to be in Sichuan?"

“How should I know? Damn river bandits. Things have been tense enough lately as it is…”

“Shh. Keep your voice down. Some young man is looking this way. Nothing good comes from getting tangled up with Murim.”

The group of merchants who met my eyes hurried away.

And they weren’t the only ones.

A fisherman whose face had been blackened by the sun grabbed his net and scurried off, while a vendor selling his catch packed up his stall at the speed of light.

In the distance, an official in formal robes watched us closely, surrounded by an escort of government troops.

Their eyes held undisguised wariness.

What the hell? This atmosphere is completely different from Sichuan.

The Yangtze River Channel League might have been a band of river pirates founded on plunder, but it had rules and an established system of its own.

I’d heard they didn’t simply pounce whenever they spotted an opportunity, kill everyone in sight, and strip the ship bare. Sometimes they even protected vessels from unaffiliated river bandits, and under normal circumstances, they only collected a set toll before letting ships pass.

They tested the waters during the Great Faction War, but in the end, they sided with the orthodox faction.

Give and take made the world go round.

During the upheaval that decided the future of Murim, the Yangtze River Channel League had backed the orthodox faction and slipped the government enough bribes to keep it satisfied.

In other words, they were hired thugs in a cloak of legality, tolerated by both sides and allowed to carry on.

They couldn’t exactly be called good people, but this was Murim, where every kind of lunatic imaginable ran wild. They might not be gentlemen, but by Murim standards, they were at least run-of-the-mill scoundrels.

That’s why ordinary people in Sichuan barely reacted to them.

Their attitude had been more like, *Those beggar bastards are still alive and back again?* They certainly hadn’t openly avoided us like this.

I tilted my head as I watched the people scatter in every direction.

Is it just a difference in atmosphere from one region to another?

But if that were all, Mu Song’s expression wouldn’t have looked so grim.

He stared at the suddenly deserted harbor with a deep frown, then called over his right-hand man.

“Have we received no word from our brothers in the League?”

“No, Stronghold Lord. They must have known we were coming, but for some reason, there has been no contact.”

“Not even from Dangyang Stronghold or Honghu Stronghold?”

“That is correct.”

“Even if the others didn’t know, Uncle Hwang is at Donghu Stronghold. There’s no way he failed to hear that we were coming…”

Mu Song muttered with a grave expression, then continued.

“Once we disembark, send out our fastest men to find out what’s happening. Contact our nearby brothers immediately as well.”

“Yes, Stronghold Lord.”

At Mu Song’s gesture, the river bandits under his command moved as one. We were no exception, having finished our preparations to disembark long ago.

Jeok Cheongang, finally leaving the Yangtze behind, led the way. I followed, then Jin Wikyung, Cheongpung, Hyuk Mujin, and Gung Gibang.

Mungyeong came too, blending so quietly into the crowd that one could almost forget he was there.

At last, Jeok Cheongang—the Fire Pokémon[2105] finally free of his type disadvantage—wore a radiant smile.

“Whew. I can finally breathe again. This is why people are meant to live with their feet on solid ground.”

But his happiness didn’t last long.

“You there. Stop.”

The voice was filled with authority. An official who had approached without us noticing swallowed nervously as he looked at us.

Then he glanced at the hundreds of government troops behind him, puffed out his chest, and continued.

“I hear you came from Sichuan. Is that correct?”

“‘You’? ‘Is that correct’?”

Jeok Cheongang blinked and echoed the official’s words back at him.

“Were you addressing this old man just now?”

“That is correct.”

“‘That is correct’?”

The official’s eyes wavered uneasily. But he quickly steeled himself and raised his voice.

“Ahem! Answer only what this official asks. State clearly where you came from and what purpose brings you here!”

“‘Ahem’? ‘Answer me’? ‘State your purpose’?”

[2105] Pokémon are creatures from a Japanese game franchise. In its battles, elemental types have strengths and weaknesses; water has an advantage over fire.

"N-no, this old man…"

"'Old man'?"

Don't. Don't do it. Please, just stop.

They said women got butterflies when a handsome man repeated someone's words like that, but from where I stood, this was a horror movie.

I hurriedly stepped in before Jeok Cheongang could drive a Flame God Palm into the arrogant official's chest.

"Talk to me instead."

"I have nothing to discuss with some wet-behind-the-ears brat!"

"…"

I'd just pulled him out of a tiger's jaws, and this was how he talked to me?

I wanted to knock his head clean off, but I held back and continued.

"We did come from Sichuan, and we have business here."

"Then what business would that be?"

"Well…"

At that moment, someone shouted excitedly.

"Steamed fish topped with lots of minced chili peppers!"

"Cheongpung, you son of a bitch!"

"Why, Benefactor? It really is delicious. It's so good that if two people were eating it and one dropped dead, the other wouldn't even notice…"

I didn't know if it was really delicious enough that one person could die without the other noticing, but from the official's expression, it was clear that we looked like people who deserved to die.

His face turned bright red as he bellowed.

"How dare you mock this official!"

"Wait, mister. That's not what he meant…"

"It is suspicious enough that you came from Sichuan under the flag of the Yangtze River Channel League, and now you claim you came here to eat steamed fish? You're the sort who won't shed a tear until you see the coffin. Guards, arrest them at once!"

"Yes, sir!"

What the hell was this development?

Before I could say another word, hundreds of government troops with military discipline drilled into them surrounded us with spears. Jin Wikyung clicked his tongue softly and stepped forward.

"You're rather quick-tempered."

Jin Wikyung was tall even by modern standards. In Murim, he was considered a giant.

The official swallowed hard as he took in Jin Wikyung's Ural Mountain shoulders[2106] and the muscles bulging beneath his clothes.

"W-who are you?"

"I am Jin Wikyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Shanxi. I won't waste words, so why don't you withdraw your men?"

Before the official could answer, Jin Wikyung continued in his deep voice.

"It seems you haven't been informed yet, but we are martial artists who received direct permission to pass from the City Lord of Sichuan Province."

"The City Lord of Sichuan Province?"

"If you doubt me, you may verify it. But before you do, I suggest you withdraw your men. There's no need to throw away perfectly good lives."

The official flinched, and the spearpoints of the government troops surrounding us trembled.

They knew it too. No matter how rigorous their training or how elite they were, they couldn't defeat us.

But that was how the world worked. The men at the bottom shed the blood, while the men at the top guarded their pride. I saw the official's eyes harden.

"How dare you… Do you even know who this official is?"

Without the slightest change in expression, Jin Wikyung replied.

"I do. Naturally, you belong to the Hubei Provincial Administration Commission, which oversees the province's civil and financial affairs. Judging by your robes, you are a Judicial Inquirer of the secondary sixth rank. Though I don't know why a man responsible for judicial affairs has come all the way out here to arrest innocent people."

"…!"

"Oh, that reminds me. Do you know a man surnamed Yi, with the given name Hongcheon?"

A trembling voice slipped between the official's lips.

"T-that person is the Provincial Administration Commissioner who was newly appointed not long ago."

"I see. I thought I'd heard something about that. From Assistant Provincial Administrator in Shanxi to Provincial Administration Commissioner of Hubei. Quite the promotion. An occasion worth celebrating."

"M-might I ask what your relationship is with the Provincial Administration Commissioner?"

Jin Wikyung smiled faintly. At some point, his posture and tone had naturally shifted into those of a man looking down at the official.

[2106] The Ural Mountains are a long mountain range in Russia that forms the traditional boundary between Europe and Asia; the comparison describes broad, massive shoulders.

“I’ve met him a few times and shared a drink or two with him. I also helped him when he needed it.”

“Gasp!”

“Why? Is there something else you’d like to hear?”

“N-no, sir!”

The official’s rigid back folded like a mollusk.

After snapping into a deep bow toward Jin Wikyung, he spun around and roared at his subordinates.

“You fools! What are you doing? Put away those vicious blades at once!”

“Y-yes, sir!”

“What sort of idiots can’t even read a situation like this? Please forgive our rudeness!”

Jin Wikyung benevolently patted the official on the shoulder.

“It’s all right. Everyone makes mistakes in life, like you did today.”

“This man Son is deeply moved by your generosity, as vast as the sea!”

“Don’t apologize to me. Apologize to these men directly. Especially the gentleman you addressed first. He is a highly respected elder of Murim.”

“I-I had no idea. Then might I ask his sobriquet…?”

“He is Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King.”

“…!”

“We came straight to Hubei after the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, aboard a ship borrowed from the Yangtze River Channel League. Oh, and of course, we didn’t come solely to eat steamed fish.”

Stop it. You’re going to make him cry.

The official looked from one of us to another with an expression that said he wanted to die, performing the remarkable feat of bowing five times a second.

Jin Wikyung nudged me lightly in the ribs.

“What do you think, my youngest? Your big brother looks cool, doesn’t he?”

“…”

“You would’ve looked cool if you hadn’t said that.”

“Once you establish connections with the government, they make many things more convenient. If you ever find yourself in trouble, try using my name.”

If he could say that with such confidence, he must have planted quite a few seeds.

According to Gung Gibang, the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s meteoric rise in such a short time was virtually unprecedented.

If Jin Mukyung, who was undoubtedly continuing his grueling training at the Jin Family even now, was a martial arts genius, then Jin Wikyung was an all-rounder who possessed everything a Family Head needed.

“My youngest, don’t you think I look cool? Hm?”

"…"

Yes. Apart from things like this, he was the perfect Family Head.

I was still trying to push away the increasingly clingy Jin Wikyung when it happened.

"Everyone, stand aside."

At the voice infused with profound internal energy, the people murmuring some distance from the harbor parted to either side.

At the same time, dozens of martial artists carrying considerable qi approached us with measured steps.

That's…

I narrowed my eyes.

Written in cloud-like calligraphy across their pure-white silk martial robes were the words:

Zhuge Clan.

Chapter 444

The Zhuge Clan.

It was a famous family bound to appear at least once in every modern wuxia[2107] novel.

Not a single character with the surname Zhuge was ever stupid, and none of them were conspicuously strong, either.

They were supposedly one of Murim's great families, yet martial arts seemed more like their minor than their major.

That made sense. The Zhuge Clan's true strength came not from their bodies, but from their minds.

They were a family of wise men versed in a broad range of scholarship, strategy, and mechanisms and formations.

As a result, the world called them the Divine Mechanism Zhuge, and in Murim, they handled practically every role that required brains.

If the strategist of the Murim Alliance in a novel you were reading didn't have a name that began with Zhuge, it almost felt wrong.

Perhaps that image of the Zhuge Clan had been lodged so firmly in my mind that seeing these martial artists stride toward us without hesitation felt strangely unfamiliar.

But unfamiliarity wasn't the only emotion I felt.

Clack-clack-clack-clack!

The Zhuge Clan's martial artists lined up on either side of the road like iron towers. A lone figure slowly walked between them.

The slender young man wore robes so white they were almost blinding.

"The stars shone unusually bright last night. It seems they were heralding the arrival of honored guests. I am the Zhuge Clan's Lesser Family Head…"

Delighted, I thrust a hand into the air and shouted.

"Galgyun!"

"Not 'Galgyun'… My name is Zhuge Gyun."

A heavy silence fell.

The Zhuge Clan's martial artists, who still had no idea who I was, looked at me as if I were some kind of madman. Jeok Cheongang looked at me with a hint of confusion.

"You know this fellow?"

"Yes. I met him at the Star-Array Grand Banquet last time. But this is the first I've heard that he's the Zhuge Clan's Lesser Family Head."

[2107] Wuxia is a genre of Chinese fiction and film about martial artists and their adventures.

“Even someone like you has friends?”

“He’s not my friend. I just call them the Three Idiots…”

“Ahem! Ahem-ahem!”

One of the Three Idiots I had met at the Star-Array Grand Banquet—the Divine Marvel Dragon Zhuge Gyun—hurriedly cleared his throat and cut me off.

Before I could say anything, he turned toward Jeok Cheongang and offered his greetings.

“Zhuge Gyun, a newcomer to Murim, pays his respects to Senior.”

Jeok Cheongang looked Zhuge Gyun up and down, then tossed out a question.

“What relation are you to Gonghu?”

“Pardon?”

“I mean the Fan-Wisdom King, Zhuge Gonghu. The bastard who served as the Murim Alliance’s chief strategist during the Great Faction War.”

I had heard both the title and the name of the Fan-Wisdom King Zhuge Gonghu.

He had served as the mind of the Murim Alliance during the Great Faction War and had been the foremost contributor to turning around the grim course of the war.

That was one reason he had been hailed as one of the Ten Kings alongside the other Supreme Peak masters.

And he calls a man like that a bastard.

I had seen Jeok Cheongang act this way so many times that I was used to it, but to everyone else, it must have been a whole new world.

Jin Wikyung swallowed hard, while the Zhuge Clan’s martial artists stood with their mouths hanging open, doubting their own ears.

Of course, our Fire King Jeok Cheongang didn’t care about any of that. Ramming straight into things with blazing force was practically the Fire Gate Clan’s trademark.

“Well? Why aren’t you answering?”

His expression was unpleasant enough already, but when he actually frowned, he looked like a murderous demon.

Even Zhuge Gyun—a lunatic who was no slouch himself—was so flustered that he stammered.

“M-my great-grandfather.”

“Is that so? No wonder you look a little like him. You look like you’ve got a decent head on your shoulders. Like you’ve got no manners, either.”

“…!”

Now that was imposing.

Since Jeok Cheongang was a man from two generations ago who had lived well past a hundred, even the elders of most prestigious clans and sects couldn't dare object when he called them, "Hey," "you," or "bastard."

He chewed people up with martial arts and digested them with seniority. He was Murim's very own Bodhidharma skull water.[2108]

As the atmosphere grew increasingly awkward, I gave Jeok Cheongang a light poke in the side.

"Come on. That's enough."

"What? Can't this old man say even that much?"

"Even so, he passed away ten years ago…"

"What do these greenhorns know? If this old man had died, Zhuge Gonghu would have done the same. He and I have been calling each other bastard for years."

"…"

"…"

Not brotherly terms. Bastardly terms.

While everyone flinched once again at his innovative choice of words, Jin Wikyung was the first to recover and address Zhuge Gyun.

"Thank you for the Zhuge Clan's hospitality."

A true professional was a true professional. At the Star-Array Grand Banquet, Zhuge Gyun had seemed like a man with a screw loose, but as the Lesser Family Head of his clan, he responded appropriately.

"Think nothing of it. I hope your journey here was not too uncomfortable."

"If a person is comfortable in both body and mind, how can he call himself a martial artist—"

"It was damn uncomfortable. How dare you make this old man come all the way here? I'll hear the reason, and if it's nothing important, then a Flame Divine Palm will…"

"Oh, seriously! I said that's enough!"

"You dare grab this old man's sleeve! Let go, you all-brawn bastard!"

While I tried to restrain Jeok Cheongang, who had suddenly flown off the handle, Jin Wikyung hurriedly continued.

"I know this is rude, but let's put the pointless conversation aside and hurry. Please, let's hurry."

"A wise decision. Zhuge Wuhou,[2109] who laid the foundations of our family, would have slapped his feather fan down and agreed."

[2108] Taekyung mixes up two Buddhist figures: the Korean monk Wonhyo is associated with an anecdote about drinking water from a skull in the dark, not Bodhidharma.

[2109] Zhuge Wuhou and Zhuge Kongming are names for Zhuge Liang, the historical Chinese strategist commonly depicted holding a feather fan.

The government troops and Zhuge Clan martial artists were the first to clear a path at the dramatic show of unity between the two Lesser Family Heads. The river bandits from the Water Dragon Stronghold who had joined our party followed behind them.

As we moved, I felt countless wary gazes following us and heard the whispers all around.

What the hell is going on?

Was this why Jin Wikyung had said we needed to pass through Hubei?

I didn't have long to wonder. The moment we climbed into the carriage, Mungyeong quietly spoke.

"It seems we're one person short."

"What?"

I looked around and only then noticed that someone was missing.

"Wait. Where did he go?"

"Over here, Benefactor!"

"…?"

When the hell had that bastard gotten over there?

Cheongpung was standing in front of a street stall that had not yet been folded, stuffing himself with freshly steamed fish. He raised one hand high and shouted.

"I'll finish eating and come!"

"Stop talking bullshit and get your ass over here!"

Please.

Just for one day, let's live like human beings. Like human beings.

With my heart in tatters, the carriage began to move.

Even as it raced down the well-kept road and disappeared into the distance, the people's gazes clung to us like shadows.

Unlike Emei, Qingcheng, and the Tang Clan—the prestigious powers of Sichuan Province—which had established their bases on mountains or in remote areas, the Zhuge Clan occupied the heart of a broad thoroughfare.

Just the people passing outside the carriage window numbered well over several hundred.

Their faces were deeply tanned, and whenever they spotted the carriage bearing the Zhuge Clan's emblem, they bowed their heads.

"Why are there so many people here?"

Zhuge Gyun, who sat across from me, answered my mutter.

"The Yangtze is Hubei's lifeline. It makes the vast surrounding lands fertile, so people naturally gather here. And since every year brings a plentiful harvest, smiles never leave their faces."

"Really? The people I saw at the ferry about one shichen[2110] ago looked like their smiles had left forever."

"That…"

Zhuge Gyun fell silent and looked away, wearing a grave expression that didn't suit him.

"I'll tell you after we reach the family compound."

Something must have happened. At the Star-Array Grand Banquet, he had been an endless fountain of nonsense, so it was telling that even he looked like this now.

Given the mood, I didn't press him and turned toward the window.

Something definitely feels wrong.

And the more time passed, the more that suspicion deepened.

The government troops, who were usually so lax, had their eyes wide open as they checked people's hopae[2111] at various points, while martial artists in ordinary clothes hid among the commoners.

The martial prowess I briefly sensed from them as we passed was far from low. Dark Heaven immediately came to mind, but Jeok Cheongang's Sound Transmission cleared up the matter a moment later.

—They're Zhuge Clan people. For some reason, they're hiding their identities and even moving covertly.

They're going this far in what's practically their own front yard?

I suddenly remembered what had happened a few days earlier and asked,

—Old Master, didn't you hear anything?

—About what?

—You know. You left with my eldest brother for a while last time.

—I did.

—Didn't you hear why we had to come to Hubei then? Something about Wudang or the Zhuge Clan?

Jeok Cheongang's brow furrowed slightly as he looked at me.

—What good would it do this old man to hear any of that?

—Pardon?

—If we're going, we're going. Why bother prying into every last detail? I merely badgered him to get here as quickly as possible. I told him I'd sink every one of the swift ships if he didn't.

—…Ah. Right.

[2110] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours.

[2111] A *hopae* was a personal identification tablet carried in premodern Korea.

I wasn't sure whether to call that cool or hotheaded.

Shaking my head, I glanced at Mungyeong.

The boy had been chatting with Hyuk Mujin with a bright smile, showing no sign of irritation. But then one of his eyebrows lifted slightly.

A private Sound Transmission reached my ears.

—What.

—…I haven't even said anything yet.

—Don't stare at me for no reason. Not if you want to see the sun rise tomorrow.

How was I supposed to breathe with him scaring me like this?

I sighed inwardly and turned my gaze beyond the carriage's latticed window.

Mount Longzhong, also called Mount Fulong because the greatest strategist under heaven—a man who had shaped the history of an era—had once lived there in seclusion.

And spread across a vast stretch of land, the Zhuge Clan finally came into view.

They said this was the wealthiest family in Hubei Province.

Their ancestor, Zhuge Kongming,[2112] had been renowned for his frugality. But his descendants had not devoted their naturally sharp minds solely to scholarship, mechanisms, and formations.

They had taken full advantage of the fertile land that yielded plentiful harvests every year and the Yangtze's waterways, which crossed the entirety of Hubei Province, to amass enormous wealth.

I began to grasp the extent of that wealth before we even passed through the Zhuge Clan's main gate.

"Why aren't we getting out? Haven't we arrived?"

Zhuge Gyun answered with an expression that seemed to say he had no idea what I was talking about.

"Pardon? It would take quite a while to walk from here to the Inner Hall. We still have seven more gates to pass through, so just remain seated."

"…It's that big?"

"This is after we reduced it. Our family suffered considerable damage during the Great Faction War."

"That's insane. You're raking in gold and silver. Didn't your ancestor leave instructions telling you to live frugally or something? Wasn't he supposed to be an incorruptible scholar?"

Without the slightest change in expression, Zhuge Gyun answered in a solemn voice.

[2112] Zhuge Wuhou and Zhuge Kongming are names for Zhuge Liang, the historical Chinese strategist commonly depicted holding a feather fan.

“Studying isn’t cheap. Do you know how expensive books are? Besides, our family also provides separate support to scholars.”

“…”

“You need a comfortable environment to pass the civil-service examinations and advance in martial arts. When you’re hungry, you can’t think about anything. You only become anxious.”

“Uh… right.”

It wasn’t what I had expected, but when I thought about it, every one of his points made sense.

After patiently explaining the importance of capital, Zhuge Gyun concluded his speech by saying that even his ancestor, Zhuge Kongming, had been born with a silver spoon in his mouth.

By then, the carriage had passed through all eight gates and was entering the Inner Hall.

“Now, please get down and follow me. The Family Head is waiting.”

“The Family Head would be…”

“My father.”

I had heard about him from Jeok Cheongang.

During the Great Faction War, Zhuge Gonghu had lost his only son. In accordance with the principle of eldest-son succession, he had bestowed the position of Lesser Family Head upon his young grandson.

That young grandson was Zhuge Feng, the Crouching Dragon Guest—the current Family Head of the Zhuge Clan and Zhuge Gyun’s father.

“Family Head, I’ve brought the honored guests.”

At Zhuge Gyun’s grave voice, now completely devoid of humor, the firmly closed doors slowly opened.

Chapter 445

Clack.

“Ah.”

Someone let out a small gasp.

The enormous library revealed when the doors opened was impressive enough, but so was the fact that they had opened without anyone touching them or using internal energy.

Even to someone who had spent his entire modern life passing through automatic doors tens of thousands of times, it was a remarkably novel experience.

Some kind of machine?

No, this was Murim. Should I call it a mechanism?

The doors contained an intricate arrangement of iron and wooden components, all precisely interlocked.

And that wasn’t all. As I slowly looked around the library, I saw unmistakable traces of similar mechanisms throughout the place.

Of course, they were crude compared to the cutting edge of modern civilization. But I had certainly never seen anything like them in any of the other prestigious great families or sects I’d visited.

That aside…

Why is nobody here?

There wasn’t even a servant or guard in sight, let alone the Family Head himself.

As everyone, myself included, stared around, Zhuge Gyun shouted.

“Family Head!”

His voice, infused with internal energy, echoed through the library.

The space wasn’t merely large. Vast was the only word for it. It was bigger than a modern soccer stadium.

Zhuge Gyun’s shout carried between the endless rows of bookshelves, but no answer came.

“What the hell? Is he not here?”

“He seems to be somewhere inside, but… Ah, this is driving me crazy.”

As if he had known this would happen, Zhuge Gyun let out a deep sigh and continued.

“He often gets like this when he becomes absorbed in something. I’m sorry, but if you could wait here for a moment, I’ll find the Family Head and—”

Jeok Cheongang, who had been looking around the library, cut him off.

“Enough. Is that really necessary?”

“Pardon? Even so, with Great Hero Jeok visiting…”

“He’ll come out when the time is right. He must have his reasons.”

For a moment, I wondered if I had heard him correctly. Of all people, I never expected those words to come from Jeok Cheongang.

Even Cheongpung dropped the candied fruit he had been bringing to his mouth.

Am I dreaming?

I was seriously considering the question when Jeok Cheongang continued with a warm smile.

“Come to think of it, this old man has never seen such a large and magnificent library in his life. Would it be all right if I looked around for a while?”

Zhuge Gyun answered with a dazed expression.

“Of course.”

“Even if I burn it down?”

“…Pardon?”

“It was a joke, you little punk. Ho-ho. How could I burn everything in sight when I’m here as a guest?”

Jeok Cheongang laughed heartily, then added,

“Knocking over a bookshelf by accident would be another matter.”

In the next instant, Jeok Cheongang shot upward like a streak of light.

At the same time, a palm strike carrying the tremendous force of ten thousand geun[2113] slammed into the nearest bookshelf.

Boom!

It happened before anyone could stop him. I stared at the scene unfolding before me, my mouth hanging open.

Oh, fuck.

Rumble…

The bookshelf, which looked to be at least three zhang[2114] tall, began to tilt.

And there were hundreds of them.

In the blink of an eye, the countless shelves packed together at regular intervals became one enormous row of dominoes.

“W-wait, wait, wait, wait!”

Crash! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The deafening roar swallowed Zhuge Gyun’s scream.

As every bookshelf came crashing down, years of accumulated dust erupted into the air and filled the library in a dense cloud.

No, I wasn’t even sure it could still be called a library. A graveyard of books would have been more appropriate.

[2113] A geun is a traditional weight unit equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg (about 13,200 lb).

[2114] A zhang is a traditional length unit equal to ten chi. Three zhang is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

It might even have become one person’s grave.

“Fatherrrr!”

Jeok Cheongang patted the wailing Zhuge Gyun on the shoulder.

“You’re the new Family Head of the Zhuge Clan now.”

“Nooo!”

Whack!

Jeok Cheongang smacked him on the back of the head and gave him an incredulous look.

“You really can’t take a joke, can you? Can’t you see your father over there, alive and well?”

Jeok Cheongang was telling the truth.

A couple of coughs came from within the thick cloud of dust, and a slender figure emerged, waving one hand as he walked toward us.

“Well, now. Cough. I’m sorry I couldn’t come out to greet you sooner. There have been an unusual number of matters requiring my attention lately. Cough.”

“At least you know. What an ill-mannered brat.”

Jeok Cheongang answered curtly and flicked his sleeve.

Whoosh!

Compressed air burst outward, scattering the dust cloud. At last, the man came fully into view.

“Ha. Seeing you like this makes me realize how much time has passed. Do you remember this old man?”

A clear voice answered.

“Of course. It was the fifth Mid-Autumn Festival[2115] after my birth. Senior ate two plates of roast duck and drank five jars of Yeoahong,[2116] then fought a duel with Great Hero Peng as the gathering drew to a close and ended up with a bloody nose.”

“What? That Thunderbolt Saber King bastard was there too? We even fought?”

“Yes. Great Hero Peng laughed loudly and struck the table, spilling wine on Senior’s knee. It was a minor disagreement.”

“That sounds like a major incident where it wouldn’t have been strange for someone to die.”

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh before continuing.

“Quite a few years have passed, but that incredible head of yours is still as sharp as ever. All right, enough nonsense. Come here. You have guests waiting for you.”

“I was planning to greet them regardless.”

[2115] The Mid-Autumn Festival is celebrated on the fifteenth day of the eighth lunar month.

[2116] Yeoahong is a traditional Chinese rice wine, also known as Daughter’s Red.

Though the middle-aged man was covered in dust, it couldn't conceal his refined appearance.

He was the youngest Sect Leader of any prestigious great family or sect I had met so far. His eyes, unusually clear and radiant, turned toward us.

"My apologies for keeping such honored guests waiting. I am Zhuge Feng."

It was a remarkably plain greeting for the Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, the foremost great family in Hubei Province and one of the central pillars of the orthodox faction.

Then, before anyone could respond, Zhuge Feng continued. The moment I heard his next words, I suddenly understood why his sobriquet was Crouching Dragon Guest.

"Time is as precious as gold, and I have no desire to take anyone else's gold. Only those who wish to remain need stay. Oh, and I've always believed people should make themselves comfortable when they talk, so please don't take this the wrong way."

I wondered what he meant until Zhuge Feng promptly flopped onto his side, paying no attention to the dust coating the floor. A laugh escaped me.

"Sure, why not? This is comfortable."

I lay down at an angle and propped my chin on one hand. The corners of his eyes curved like crescent moons.

Though everyone looked dumbfounded, they sat down one by one and listened to Zhuge Feng.

Mu Song tried to leave, saying he had to visit a Yangtze River Channel League stronghold in Hubei, but one remark from Zhuge Feng stopped him in his tracks.

"I won't stop you if you wish to leave, but what I am about to say concerns you deeply as well, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song."

"…!"

Mu Song hesitated, then remained behind. Surprisingly, Mungyeong, who had seemed the most likely to leave first, stayed quietly where he was.

Then again, with everyone else remaining, leaving alone might have drawn even more attention.

The Zhuge Clan's intelligence network had already informed Zhuge Feng that this young medical apprentice was the Divine Physician's Disciple. He gave Mungyeong a curious look, but soon turned away and began to speak.

"It was exactly one month ago. I was in the library, reading the *Records of the Grand Historian*[2117] for the eighty-fifth time, when I heard the news."

[2117] The *Records of the Grand Historian* is a history of ancient China compiled by Sima Qian.

The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were the leading powers of their respective provinces.

With roots stretching back anywhere from a hundred years to several centuries, each possessed a dense intelligence network that allowed them to know their territory like the palm of their hand.

The Zhuge Clan was no exception.

“The Sea Serpent Society had disappeared.”

“The Sea Serpent Society? What’s that, Benefactor?”

“I don’t know either.”

Unlike the bewildered Cheongpung and me, everyone else’s eyes widened.

Mu Song’s reaction stood out more than anyone else’s.

“Th-the Sea Serpent Society?”

“Yes, the very one you know. The association formed by the countless fishermen and boatmen of Hubei Province.”

Ah. Now I understood.

I had never heard of the Sea Serpent Society, but I could guess what kind of organization it was.

To put it simply and dispense with all the old-fashioned explanations, it was a sort of professional association.

Just as each region had a Hunter Association, Hubei Province had—or rather, used to have—an association of fishermen called the Sea Serpent Society.

And this was unquestionably good news, at least for Mu Song. The faint smile tugging at the corners of his mouth was proof enough.

“I cannot say what the Zhuge Clan thinks of this, but as someone devoted to the League, I welcome the news. The Sea Serpent Society caused my Master no end of trouble.”

“I thought you would feel that way. At least within Hubei Province, it was the only organization capable of standing against the Yangtze River Channel League.”

Tributaries of the Yangtze ran throughout Hubei Province like a spiderweb.

No matter how powerful the Yangtze River Channel League was, it must have been vastly outnumbered by the people who made their living from fishing.

Though Hubei was outside the Sichuan territory under his responsibility, Mu Song laughed heartily at the news that one powerful rival had disappeared.

“But how did they end up disbanding? Did they happen to smuggle salt or something…?[2118]”

Zhuge Feng shook his head.

[2118] Salt was a state monopoly in imperial China, and smuggling it was a serious crime that could bring execution; powerful smuggling gangs were notorious.

“Of course not. Even if they had been smuggling salt, the Sea Serpent Society would never have handled it so carelessly. And if they had been caught, a fleet dispatched by order of the Son of Heaven would already be filling the Yangtze throughout Hubei.”

“Then was it an internal conflict?”

“I don’t think you properly understood what I said.”

His clear, transparent eyes fixed on Mu Song.

As he faced Mu Song’s confusion, Zhuge Feng continued slowly.

“The Sea Serpent Society disappeared. Someone crushed it utterly.”

“…!”

“The night before I received that report, a banquet was held to celebrate the Society Head’s eightieth birthday. Forty-five shipowners who had sworn loyalty to him and roughly a thousand members of the Sea Serpent Society attended. They drank until past midnight and launched dozens of pleasure boats onto the waters of Red Cliffs. And that was the last of it.”

The next morning, an old boatman who rose at dawn found the waters of Red Cliffs choked with corpses and the wreckage of brutally shattered boats.

The Society Head and the organization’s core members, including dozens of shipowners, had all met their deaths at Red Cliffs. The Sea Serpent Society had lost both its head and its body.

Nothing can move without either.

The Sea Serpent Society, which had stood shoulder to shoulder with the Yangtze River Channel League and wielded power throughout Hubei Province for decades, disappeared just like that.

“H-how could such a thing happen…?”

“It is strange that you, of all people, knew nothing about it.”

Zhuge Feng stared steadily at the speechless Mu Song.

“Do you know who moved first after the incident at Red Cliffs became known? The authorities? The Sea Serpent Society members who were lucky enough to survive? No. It was the Yangtze River Channel League. They invaded the Sea Serpent Society’s territory and took control of the Yangtze with astonishing speed.”

“…Great Hero Zhuge.”

Mu Song’s face hardened.

Like the rest of us, he seemed to have finally realized why he had needed to remain.

“Are you saying you suspect me? The League?”

“Of course I didn’t. The Great Hero Hwang of Donghu Stronghold whom I know is not such a foolish man. He is different from the other foolish, violent Stronghold Lords.”

Zhuge Feng brushed the dust from his shoulder and smiled faintly at Mu Song.

“That was certainly what I thought—until the Dongting Fisherman, who had publicly condemned the Yangtze River Channel League, disappeared three days ago.”

“…!”

At that moment, unrest spread through the group, and a familiar notification rang in my ears.

Ding.

Chapter 446

Ding.

SYSTEM

A Quest has been generated.

A familiar System notification.

Immediately afterward, a translucent holographic window visible only to me appeared in midair.

SYSTEM

Quest
Another Chaos
An ominous air hangs over the once-peaceful Hubei Province. The clear waters of the Yangtze have been dyed red with blood, the once-mighty Sea Serpent Society has fallen amid countless deaths, and the Dongting Fisherman, who publicly condemned the Yangtze River Channel League, has disappeared.
If someone uncovers the truth behind these events and finds the culprit, the chaos will subside.
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Uncover the truth behind the events *(Incomplete)*
Reward: ???
Failure: The chaos in Hubei Province will worsen, and further incidents will occur
Will you accept the Quest?
Y / N

A Quest…

I slowly looked around.

Mu Song sat with his lips pressed tightly together, while Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng stared at him with a cold smile.

Jeok Cheongang frowned as he watched the two of them, and Mungyeong sat expressionlessly.

And finally… there was Jin Wikyung, calmly observing the entire situation.

So he did know.

According to Zhuge Feng, the Sea Serpent Society Head and a thousand of his men had been buried beneath the waters of Red Cliffs a fortnight ago. Jin Wikyung must have heard about it on his way to Sichuan.

And adding Hubei to our return route means the leadership in Henan approved it too.

Now that the bloody incidents in Shaolin and Sichuan had exposed Dark Heaven's existence to the entire world, the series of events unfolding in Hubei could not be taken lightly.

If this was Dark Heaven's scheme, we had to stop it.

And if the Yangtze River Channel League had taken advantage of the chaos caused by Dark Heaven to carry out some plot of its own, they had to be punished as an example to others.

Jin Wikyung had not come here as the Lesser Family Head or acting Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

He had come as an inspector for the new Murim Alliance that would soon be formed.

What that meant was simple.

I have to stand with Jin Wikyung too.

Besides, the Quest carried no penalty. There was little point in asking whether I would accept when I was already in the same boat as him.

I muttered inwardly.

Yes.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest accepted!

Quest Another Chaos has been registered in the Quest Window! Quest information may be updated depending on the situation.

I wasn't sure what else there was to update.

Judging by Zhuge Feng's words and the atmosphere I had sensed on the way to the Zhuge Clan, all of Hubei Province had already branded the Yangtze River Channel League as the culprit and was pointing fingers at them.

But…

"Are you certain the Yangtze River Channel League is responsible?"

Personally, I didn't think we could jump to conclusions just yet.

My question broke the heavy silence. Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng smiled faintly.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. You seem to have many questions about this matter.”

“I can’t say I don’t.”

“Go ahead, provided we do not waste each other’s valuable time.”

“First, I would like to ask whether there is any evidence.”

“Evidence?”

“Yes. All you have is circumstantial evidence, don’t you? At the very least, shouldn’t there be a witness who saw the Yangtze River Channel League attack the Sea Serpent Society on the night of the incident at Red Cliffs?”

“A witness. What else?”

“You still haven’t determined what happened to the Dongting Fisherman, who publicly condemned the Yangtze River Channel League.”

“Continue.”

I glanced at Jeok Cheongang before going on.

“According to what I once heard from the old—no, from my Master, the Dongting Fisherman was a Supreme Peak master who belonged to neither the orthodox nor the unorthodox faction.”

“Correct. The Dongting Fisherman spent his entire life near Dongting Lake and built friendships with renowned figures from all walks of life.”

The Dongting Fisherman was well known even in Murim, where strange and extraordinary figures were hardly rare.

It was unusual enough that he had never joined either the orthodox or unorthodox faction and had spent his entire life near Dongting Lake. But the formidable martial arts he performed with the single fishing rod he always carried were also famous throughout Murim.

“I couldn’t understand how a Supreme Peak master like the Dongting Fisherman could disappear without anyone noticing.”

“What about it do you find difficult to understand?”

“If someone killed the Dongting Fisherman, his opponent must have been a master of equal or greater skill. When two Supreme Peak masters really go at it, all hell breaks loose. There’s no way no one would notice.”

“You certainly speak plainly. Continue.”

“And this might be disrespectful to Senior Mu Song.”

Mu Song, who had regained some of his composure after I stepped in, nodded.

“Speak. I don’t mind.”

“Really?”

“Of course.”

“Well, if you say so.”

I spoke cautiously.

“Honestly, does the Yangtze River Channel League have a master of that caliber? From what I’ve seen, it sure didn’t seem like it.”

“…!”

“…!”

What? You said you didn’t mind. You told me to speak.

Mu Song looked considerably less fine than before, so I quietly amended my statement.

“Ah, of course, I’m only talking about Hubei. I respect the Seafaring King. I even enjoyed the drama—no, anyway, I’m a huge fan.”

“…”

“Actually, when I was little, I dreamed of becoming a river bandit. The Grand Line![2119] The great Yangtze!”

“…”

All right. My fault.

Why did I feel guilty when I was technically trying to help him?

Zhuge Feng rescued me from the crisis with a single sentence.

“There is a master of that caliber.”

“What? There is? You’re not lying? Seriously?”

“…”

Leaving Mu Song looking dejected once again, Zhuge Feng continued slowly.

“Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung.”

“Yangtze One Saber. Yangtze One Saber…”

The sobriquet sounded vaguely familiar, but the name itself was new to me. Surely he wasn’t the Hwang Chung from *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*.[2120]

He does seem to be the Uncle Hwang Mu Song mentioned when we first arrived in Hubei.

As I tilted my head at the unfamiliar name, Jeok Cheongang cut in sharply.

“Yangtze One Saber? That bastard who’s the Seafaring King’s sworn brother?”

“Yes. I imagine you know him as well, Senior.”

“I crossed paths with him once during the Great Faction War. He was calm and clever for a river bandit. I remember thinking the young fellow had a decent personality and considerable martial talent… It seems he finally crossed the wall.”

“If he had not helped the Seafaring King, the Yangtze River Channel League as it exists today would not be here.”

[2119] The Grand Line is an ocean route in *One Piece*, a Japanese pirate story also adapted for television.

[2120] Hwang Chung is the Korean reading of Huang Zhong, a general from *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*.

“You call that something worth saying? Without someone to keep him in check, how could the Seafaring King, that foul-tempered bastard, have ruled the Yangtze?”

Wow. That was practically spitting in his face.

Mu Song’s lips twitched as though he had something to say after hearing his Master insulted right in front of him, but Jeok Cheongang silenced him with a single fierce glare.

I seized the opening and quickly spoke up.

“Then are you saying Yangtze One Saber killed the Dongting Fisherman?”

Zhuge Feng considered the question for a moment, then nodded.

“Most likely.”

“Most likely?”

“Nothing has been proven. We have no certainty, only suspicions and circumstantial evidence. But many witnesses can testify to where the Dongting Fisherman went before he disappeared.”

“And where was that?”

Zhuge Feng looked at Mu Song and continued slowly.

“Donghu Stronghold. He headed for the headquarters of Donghu Stronghold, where Yangtze One Saber, Great Hero Hwang Chung, serves as Stronghold Lord. And he was never seen again.”

“That’s impossible!”

Those words had not come from me.

Mu Song shot to his feet, the veins standing out on his neck as he shouted.

“Uncle Hwang would never do such a thing!”

He, too, was one of the disciples who had inherited the Seafaring King’s ultimate technique.

The qi pressure radiating from Mu Song, who had reached the upper limits of the Peak realm, stirred the dust settled around us.

Zhuge Feng covered his mouth with his sleeve, gave a small cough, and answered calmly.

“Why do you say that?”

“You know as well as I do, Family Head! During the Great Faction War, Uncle Hwang persuaded my Master to side with the orthodox faction. He is also one of the moderates within our League! There is no possibility that a man like him would destroy the Sea Serpent Society in this manner and kill the Dongting Fisherman!”

“‘No possibility’? What an empty and meaningless thing to say. Circumstances change, and so do people. A wise man such as myself deduces the outcome from the circumstances.”

Zhuge Feng remained so composed that Mu Song's anger seemed almost pointless.

"I will say this plainly: I am not convinced that the Yangtze River Channel League is behind this. But every circumstance points to your League."

"Why? Because once the Sea Serpent Society, which opposed our League for so many years, disappeared, our brothers moved in to fill the void? Or because the Dongting Fisherman happened to disappear on his way to visit Uncle Hwang?"

"Both."

"Did you even ask our brothers what happened?"

"Not yet."

"Then why—!"

Just as Mu Song was about to shout, Zhuge Feng's quiet voice pierced the ears of everyone in the room, including me.

"If no one from the Yangtze River Channel League has shown themselves, whom could I possibly ask?"

"…!"

"…!"

"A full month has passed. Did you think our family, Wudang, and the authorities had done nothing all this time and were simply casting baseless suspicion upon the Yangtze River Channel League?"

Silence settled over the room.

Everyone stared wordlessly at Zhuge Feng and Mu Song.

Unlike Mu Song, who had frozen like a statue, Zhuge Feng continued smoothly.

"Two days after the incident at Red Cliffs, Dangyang Stronghold and Honghu Stronghold—which had swiftly seized the Sea Serpent Society's territory—vanished without a trace. Every last person."

"…Then what about Donghu Stronghold?"

"Someone once told me that Donghu Stronghold was a natural fortress built on the water. I tried to see for myself, and they were right. Now that even the Sea Serpent Society's core boatmen have all been drowned, we could not enter Donghu Stronghold by crossing the waters of Tianling Falls."

The mysterious grandeur of nature sometimes refused all human intrusion.

The Tianling Falls Zhuge Feng mentioned were clearly the passage to Donghu Stronghold, one that only a tiny number of boatmen could navigate.

Someone counted among the finest boatmen in the Yangtze River Channel League or the Sea Serpent Society—or someone who had spent his entire life on the Yangtze in Hubei…

The Dongting Fisherman must have been one of them.

"The Dongting Fisherman and the late Sea Serpent Society Head were close friends. Enraged by his friend's death, he publicly condemned your League,

launched a boat, and crossed Tianling Falls—the very same Tianling Falls where we have sunk dozens of ships over the past month.”

Zhuge Feng abruptly rose and began walking at a leisurely pace.

He clicked his tongue softly at the fallen bookshelf, then rummaged through the towering piles of books as he continued.

“But did you know this? Although we failed to cross Tianling Falls, the Yangtze, after accepting dozens of ships as tribute, tossed us a gift as if out of generosity.”

Scrape. Crash!

A precariously balanced stack of books came tumbling down, sending dust billowing into the air.

Covered in pale dust, Zhuge Feng adjusted his cap and straightened.

Something dark and battered lay in his hand.

“That’s…”

“Your guess is correct, Successor Beggar.”

Zhuge Feng nodded at Gung Gibang’s murmur.

“The Black Bamboo Fishing Rod. The Dongting Fisherman’s signature weapon, the only one of its kind in all Murim.”

“…!”

“Well then, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song.”

Zhuge Feng slowly raised the broken Black Bamboo Fishing Rod.

He pointed it at the wide-eyed Mu Song as though about to run him through.

“You will take the lead and guide us beyond Tianling Falls to Donghu Stronghold. I intend to see with my own two eyes exactly what happened there.”

Chapter 447

Whoosh.

Silence hung over the swift ship as it cut rapidly through the current.

The river pirates of Water Dragon Stronghold rowed like machines, their mouths clamped shut, while Mu Song stared straight ahead with a rigid expression.

What a fantastic atmosphere.

I clicked my tongue inwardly and looked around.

Four swift ships were currently bound for Donghu Stronghold.

But the mood aboard them was worlds apart from when we had been sailing toward Hubei.

The unfamiliar faces now filling the ships were the reason.

The Zhuge Clan. And Wudang.

Disciples of the two prestigious factions that divided Hubei Province between them filled all four vessels.

One glance was enough to tell that they were elites, handpicked in preparation for possible bloodshed. Every last one of them was an exceptional martial artist.

And at their center stood two men.

“The wind seems unusually strong today, Family Head Zhuge.”

Zhuge Feng answered the old Daoist in an untroubled voice.

“You need not worry. If the wind is blowing like this, things will actually be easier for us.”

“Why is that? I understand dozens of ships have already sunk in winds weaker than this.”

“The boatmen’s skill is one factor, but the swift ships that symbolize the Yangtze River Channel League are in a class of their own. Rather than being swept away by strong winds, they can catch the wind and surge forward with even greater force.”

“I have heard some talk about swift ships as well… but I do not know the details, as my experience is limited. I have spent my entire life in Murim, yet it feels as though I have wasted it.”

“You have spent all that time at Wudang’s headquarters, so it is only natural that you would not know. But… may I ask what became of the matter you mentioned last time?”

“Our Sect Leader is personally working on it together with the disciples of our main sect. As for me, I was sent here instead, since all I was doing was sitting around and consuming the sect’s grain.”

“Doing nothing but consuming grain? With Perfected Being Hyeongong joining us, this junior feels as though he has gained an army of thousands.”

Zhuge Feng was not merely being polite. He meant every word.

Perfected Being Hyeongong.

That was the Daoist name of the old man in the heavily patched robe, with a single worn Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword hanging at his waist.

Neither his position within Wudang nor his generational seniority in Murim was inferior to Zhuge Feng's.

If anything, he stood equal to Zhuge Feng—or even above him.

Unlike Zhuge Feng, who had yet to turn sixty, Perfected Being Hyeongong was a master of the previous generation who had distinguished himself during the Great Faction War. He was also the current Wudang Sect Leader's Junior Brother.

And one of the Supreme Peak masters Wudang is so proud of.

Perfected Being Hyeongong was the swordsman said to have reached the ultimate stage of Wudang's greatest technique, the Taiji Wisdom Sword.

Even as Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, Zhuge Feng spoke to him with marked respect in front of everyone. That alone showed the regard he had for Hyeongong.

Of course, there was one exception to all this.

"That little punk has grown."

At the words of Jeok Cheongang—Murim's own Bodhidharma-tier[2121] old-timer—I muttered in disbelief.

"He sure has. He's grown so much his beard turned white."

"How old was he the last time I saw him? Thirty? Hah. Time certainly flies. Those soft-fuzzed little brats have all become Sect Leaders and Elders."

"Soft fuzz? At thirty, wouldn't he have had a full bush down there?"

Jeok Cheongang glared at me with fire in his eyes.

"Judging by the way you keep nitpicking my every word, you must want every hair below your waist plucked out."

"No, why would you say something like that?"

I had absolutely no desire to receive a Fire King Zilean[2122] waxing on the deck of a swift ship.

I waved my hands at the speed of light, then stole a sidelong glance at Jeok Cheongang.

"Since we're on the subject, may I ask your venerable age?"

"Venerable?"

Even under normal circumstances, Jeok Cheongang treated being called old as another way of asking him to kill you. I awkwardly tried again.

"…Then, your age?"

"My age?"

[2121] Bodhidharma is a legendary Buddhist monk associated with Shaolin in martial-arts tradition.

[2122] Zilean is an elderly, bearded character in the video game *League of Legends*. The name combines his with Jeok Cheongang's Fire King title.

Seriously, what more did he want? The man was over a hundred.

I asked with all the exasperation I could muster.

“Cheongang, how old are you?”

Whack!

Right. I knew that would happen.

Jeok Cheongang smacked the back of my head like a bolt of lightning, then answered in a bored voice.

“I stopped counting after I passed one hundred.”

“So how long ago was the last time you counted?”

“Five thousand years ago. Satisfied?”

Cheongpung, who had been dangling from the nearby bow, dropped his jaw.

“Wow! Five thousand years old!”

“…Does that little punk not know how to doubt anything?”

“…That’s just how he is. Anyway, you look unbelievably young for your age.”

Jeok Cheongang stared hard at me.

“Would you like to know more?”

“Of course not.”

Honestly, I did want to know, but judging by his expression, this was something I was better off not knowing.

He was sensitive about his age at the best of times. Worse, being aboard a swift ship racing over rougher currents and through stronger winds than ever seemed to be causing him tremendous stress.

“When the hell is this goddamned piece of wood going to stop?”

Right then, as though it had heard his complaint, the goddamned piece of wood sped up even more.

Whoooosh!

A column of water shot high into the air, and the once-steady hull began rocking from side to side.

Cheongpung cheered at the sudden violent motion like a child visiting an amusement park on Children’s Day.[2123]

Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang, who still had not recovered from their little dip in the Yangtze, let out ear-splitting screams. Mungyeong alone remained perfectly balanced, but when he noticed everyone looking at him, he tactfully grabbed the railing.

And Jeok Cheongang…

“Uhh! Uhhhhhhhh!”

[2123] Children’s Day is a South Korean holiday celebrating children, observed on May 5.

He was panicking so badly that no one would have guessed his title was the Fire King.

Good heavens, look at those bulging eyes. He could be used in a Gangnam plastic surgeon's subway advertisement as a successful double-eyelid surgery case.

Dodging the water splashing into my face, I shouted at Mu Song.

"Senior! Could you slow down a little—"

"That will be difficult."

Mu Song cut me off sharply.

Like a man born and raised on the Yangtze, he stood tall as though his feet were planted on level ground. He raised one hand and pointed ahead.

"Can you see it?"

See what?

I narrowed my eyes and stared where he was pointing.

I drew up my internal energy and focused it into my eyes. My dramatically enhanced vision pierced the dense fog blanketing the churning river.

That's…

I saw it.

A passage so narrow that even swift ships, among the sleekest of all vessels, could barely squeeze through two abreast.

And directly before it, a violent whirlpool twisting like a blade.

Whoooosh! Crack!

A massive log that had drifted in from parts unknown was caught in the whirlpool, which stretched more than a hundred zhang[2124] in radius. Unable to withstand the crushing water pressure, it snapped apart.

Some of the splintered pieces were flung away and smashed into a huge rock standing behind the whirlpool like a gatekeeper, shattering into fragments.

A whirlpool like that in a river? Not the sea, but a river?

The sight was as wondrous as it was chilling.

And everyone aboard the swift ships knew the identity of that monstrous whirlpool.

"Tianling Falls!"

Someone shouted the words like a scream.

That was right. This was Tianling Falls.

A work of nature that had transformed Donghu Stronghold of the Yangtze River Channel League into a natural fortress—and a monster that had swallowed countless lives and ships over the centuries.

[2124] A *zhang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred zhang is about 303 m (994 ft).

Looking as though he might suffocate at any moment, Jeok Cheongang declared, “Turn the ship around. I would rather fight the Great Faction War all over again than cross that.”

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin spoke next, their faces suggesting they had already suffocated.

“Senior Mu Song. Please save us. I would rather beg in a beggars’ den.”

“Captain, thank you for everything. I’m done with Murim. I want to go home and sell silk.”

“…It looks like your soul will be sold before the silk.”

Not that I wasn’t scared myself.

Watching that enormous whirlpool rush toward us made me feel like an ant tumbling into an antlion’s pit.

Fuck. We’re going to smash against that rock and get blown to pieces, then get sucked straight down like someone flushed a toilet.

Before the terror of nature itself, even the System and Supreme Peak martial arts seemed useless.

If someone dropped me into the middle of the Yangtze, I was confident I could somehow swim to shore. But if I got caught in a whirlpool like that…

Then I really was finished.

“Whew. Whew.”

As I took deep breaths, a thick hand settled on my shoulder.

“My youngest.”

Even as a fairly tall man myself, I had to tilt my head back to look up at the giant beside me. Jin Wikyung spoke with a calm expression.

“Do not worry about a thing.”

His composure alone made me want to call him Eldest Brother.

Putting aside Jeok Cheongang, who had a pathological hatred of water, even I had reached the Supreme Peak realm and was still feeling my blood run cold. Yet Jin Wikyung, whose martial arts were far below ours, did not waver in the slightest.

So this is why he’s my eldest brother. Why he’s the Lesser Family Head.

“Eldest Brother…”

“Yes.”

Jin Wikyung smiled faintly and nodded.

“Even in death, the bond between our brothers will last forever.”

“What?”

“I can see our deceased parents hovering before my eyes. It is as though they are beckoning to us from Tianling Falls.”

“…Isn’t Father still alive?”

“We lost contact with him again a long time ago. Let us simply consider him dead.”

Eldest brother, my ass. He's just a big bastard.

And while he was at it, he had declared our perfectly alive father dead just because the man had dumped the family responsibilities on him and run away.

Shit…

I looked around. Most of the people aboard were already half out of their minds, surrendering their bodies to the beat of Mother Nature.

With my last shred of hope, I looked at Mu Song.

"Senior Mu Song."

"I'm sorry, but it is too late to stop."

Whoooosh! Crack!

"Oh, fuck. He's right."

Mu Song nodded, his expression grim.

"Hold on tight. My men and I will do our best as well."

"What? What do you mean, do your best?"

"Do you think every province has its own Tianling Falls? I have only crossed it three or four times, when I came to Hubei to visit Uncle Hwang. We have no choice but to trust in the League's swift ships and the skills we have honed over the years."

"W-wait. So you're saying… you're a Tianling Falls newbie?"

"I do not know why you are suddenly bringing up Liu Bei,[2125] but of course I am unfamiliar with it. Ever since leaving headquarters and becoming a Stronghold Lord, I have spent all my time in Sichuan."

He had a point.

A fucking punchable point.

Half out of my mind, I barely squeezed out my voice.

"You've got to be kidding me. Why are you only telling us something this important now?"

"Great Hero Zhuge told me not to tell anyone else."

What?

My head snapped around at lightning speed. The disciples of both factions stood rigid with tension, and at their center was one man.

Zhuge Feng met my gaze and laughed heartily as the rising spray pelted his face.

"A wise man leads his allies, while a strategist deceives even his allies! Now that we have all climbed onto the tiger's back, let us ride it to the bitter end!"

"…!"

"…!"

Was this really happening?

[2125] Korean *nyubi* ("newbie") sounds like *Yubi*, the Korean name for Liu Bei.

Every last one of us was left speechless.

Jeok Cheongang, meanwhile, lost his mind.

“That fucking son of a bitch…!”

It was one of the greatest fits of rage I had ever witnessed.

But just as Jeok Cheongang rolled his eyes back until only the whites showed and prepared to charge—

“Everyone, hold on tight!”

At Mu Song’s urgent shout, the whirlpool of Tianling Falls opened its maw wide and slammed into the swift ship.

KRA-KOOOOM!

Chapter 448

A Supreme Peak master could perform feats straight out of an old folktale—erasing several zhang[2126] of distance in a single step, leaping upward by stepping on empty air, and bringing down a cliff with one punch.

But…

“Hold on ti—aaaaah!”

KRA-KOOOOM!

We were not on solid ground, but in the middle of the Yangtze, a river as vast as the open sea.

Before a massive whirlpool hundreds of zhang[2127] across, the swift ship carrying me was no more than a tiny leaf.

BOOM!

“Whoa, whoa, whoaaaa!”

“Aaaaargh!”

The tremendous pressure of the water slammed into the swift ship’s side. The racing vessel was hurled into the air and began to tilt.

As the world slowly turned upside down, Jin Wikyung clung to my torso as though I were a life jacket and screamed.

“Mother! I’m coming!”

“Where do you think you’re going? Let go!”

“Father! If you’re watching, tell me the answer!”

What fucking answer? There isn’t one.

But the bigger problem was that Jin Wikyung was not alone. Gung Gibang, Hyuk Mujin, and even the disciples of the Zhuge Clan and Wudang had all been driven half out of their minds.

The only ones who had managed to keep their composure were the Supreme Peak masters, myself included.

“Uhh! Uhhhhh! Water! Wateeer!”

“…”

Correction. There was one exception.

I grabbed Jeok Cheongang, who was screaming at the top of his lungs with his eyes squeezed shut, and thrust my free hand into the air with all my strength.

Flame Divine Palm!

BOOM!

Compressed air exploded outward on a wave of powerful internal energy.

[2126] A zhang is ten traditional length units of approximately 30.3 cm each, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[2127] A zhang is ten traditional length units of approximately 30.3 cm each, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Part of the blade-like whirlpool scattered, and the vessel, which had been plunging upside down toward the river, barely managed to right itself.

But it was far too soon to feel relieved.

A second and then a third whirlpool were bearing down on the falling swift ship.

I can't do this alone. At a time like this…

A thought flashed through my mind like lightning, and I shouted a single name.

"Cheongpung!"

"Yes!"

Cheongpung nodded as though he understood perfectly and flung both arms into the air.

"Kiya-hoo!"

"Not 'kiya-hoo,' you lunatic! Do what I did!"

"Ah. Yes, Benefactor!"

Cheongpung had been enjoying the Wolmido Disco Pang Pang[2128] all by himself, but now he snapped both sleeves.

The Taeeul Miri Palm, one of Huashan's proudest techniques, transformed into dozens of flower petals that lashed through the air.

BOOM-BOOM-BOOM!

It could not match the destructive power of the Flame Divine Palm, but in a situation like this, the Taeeul Miri Palm's far wider range made it ideal.

When the blade-like currents of Tianling Falls faltered, the disciples of the Zhuge Clan and Wudang seemed to recover the senses that had briefly abandoned them.

"Ha-ha-ha! The tiger is running wild! Disciples of our family, unleash the Great Heavenly Star Divine Palm!"

Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng issued the order as he swept the feather fan in his hand.

Though he had yet to cross the wall into the Supreme Peak realm, his mastery of fan techniques alone was said to rival that of a Supreme Peak master.

WHOOOOSH!

A breeze stirred along the fan's ribs, then swelled into a mighty wind that held back the whirlpool.

A towering surge rose like a triangular wave, threatening to swallow the swift ship, only to be stopped by the wind.

At that moment—

SWISH!

A streak of light shot from Perfected Being Hyeongong's waist and swept through the air.

[2128] Wolmido Disco Pang Pang is a Korean amusement-park ride in which riders sit on a rotating platform while the operator jolts and spins it.

Taiji Wisdom Sword.

The streak of light flashed through everything in its path, cleaving space and slicing through the wind. The wall of water raised by Tianling Falls seemed to split apart for an instant, then shattered completely.

SPLAAASH!

Spray burst in every direction.

Drenched in an enormous volume of cold water, Jeok Cheongang's eyes flew open like a man waking from sleep.

Then he glared at the whirlpool, flames streaming from his eyes, and roared.

"You wet, smelly, filthy things!"

"…"

He wasn't exactly wrong, but why did he sound so pathetic?

Contrary to what I thought, however, the internal energy erupting from Jeok Cheongang's sleeves was overwhelmingly powerful.

"Get the hell out of here!"

FWOOOSH—KRA-KOOOOM!

Several jiazi[2129] of Scorching Yang Qi burst forth at once.

The moisture filling the air evaporated, and the tremendous recoil sent the swift ship shooting forward like an arrow.

"Kiya-hoo!"

"Cheongpung, you lunatic!"

"Oh. Sorry, Benefactor!"

BOOM-BOOM-BOOM!

Palm forces erupted without pause as we fought to protect the vessel, while Tianling Falls sought to sink the uninvited guests who had trespassed upon its domain.

Mu Song gritted his teeth hard enough to draw blood, the veins bulging in his neck.

"Hard to port! Turn together!"

"Aaaaargh!"

BANG!

Amid the chaos, the young medical apprentice blended in by screaming with everyone else while secretly firing off a palm force. Only Jeok Cheongang, Cheongpung, and I knew what he had done.

"One, two!"

"Now! Row with every last bit of strength you have!"

SPLAAASH!

[2129] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; here it measures accumulated internal energy.

Their efforts paid off.

The four swift ships carrying hundreds of passengers drove onward through the whirlpools, farther and farther ahead.

The moment we cleared Tianling Falls, the exhausted passengers sprawled across the decks without the slightest concern for appearances.

But there was an exception to everything.

His eyes red around the edges, Jeok Cheongang stared at the waters of the Yangtze, now calm as though nothing had happened. Then he abruptly spoke.

“As the current Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan, I hereby declare that, as of this time tomorrow, the Zhuge Clan shall be our sect’s public enemy.”

“…”

“Every bastard bearing the Zhuge name should be seized and thrown into that godforsaken Tianling Falls. Any objections?”

“What if I have one?”

“I’ll throw you in with them.”

“Then I have no objections.”

“Good. Seize that goddamn bastard at once and bring him before me.”

At the end of Jeok Cheongang’s blazing gaze was a swift ship following several dozen zhang[2130] behind us. Zhuge Feng sat at its bow, waving his feather fan.

“Ha-ha, Senior! Please set aside your anger!”

“…Are you laughing?”

Even I wanted to kill him.

Bringing down a cliff would have been easier. Just imagine being sucked into a whirlpool in the middle of the vast Yangtze, with nowhere to flee.

People tossed around names like Stepping on Empty Air and Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water as though they were simple tricks, but both techniques consumed tremendous amounts of internal energy. Rescuing several hundred people would have been unthinkable.

What the hell is something like that doing in a river? It isn’t even the sea.

There was a reason it was called Tianling Falls.

Then again, if it had merely been a rough stretch of water, the Zhuge Clan and Wudang would have stormed Donghu Stronghold long ago.

Even as I thought this, Jeok Cheongang’s fury continued racing toward its peak.

[2130] A zhang is ten traditional length units of approximately 30.3 cm each, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“Turn the ship around at once! Zhuge Feng, Crouching Dragon Guest—whatever that bastard calls himself, this old man will break both his legs today and leave him bedridden for the rest of his life!”

“Calm down. Please calm down.”

“Do I look like I can calm down right now? I already hate water, and now I’ve suffered through this because we came to some godforsaken place! The man who claims to have crossed it several times can’t even find the right channel and just stands there groaning! At this point, are you a river bandit or a ferryman to the afterlife?”

At the sight of Jeok Cheongang raging like a madman, Mu Song, who had been lying spread-eagled on the deck, flinched and pushed himself upright.

“P-please calm yourself, Great Hero. I never dreamed Tianling Falls would be this bad, either.”

“You’ve been here several times and didn’t know? If you don’t know, does your life as a river bandit end here? Should I end your life here, too?”

“T-that’s not it. The currents of Tianling Falls have grown abnormally strong compared to before…”

“Grown stronger? What kind of bullshit is that? It has barely rained this year, and you dare try to deceive this old man with sweet talk that will be exposed at once?”

“I-I’m telling the truth! How could I dare lie to the Fire King?”

Hmm.

Mu Song had a point. Who would dare lie to Fire King Jeok Cheongang?

If he caught you lying, losing a hand would be the least of your worries. Your whole body would end up roasted medium-rare.

Still, can the current really get that much stronger when there hasn’t been much rain?

Forget it. I wasn’t a meteorologist or an ecosystem researcher. Thinking about it would get me nowhere.

I clicked my tongue softly and addressed Jeok Cheongang, who had not stopped berating Mu Song.

“Old Master.”

“When we return, do your job properly. If you make this old man suffer through something like that again, I’ll storm the headquarters of the Yangtze River Channel League, burn every ship to ashes, and throw that Seafaring King bastard into Tianling Falls along with the Zhuge Clan bastards… What is it? Tell me later.”

“That’s not it. I think we’ve arrived.”

“What!”

Tap-tap-tap-tap!

He moved at Quick Attack speed.

Jeok Cheongang flung Mu Song aside, crossed the swift ship in a single step, and stared straight ahead with his eyes wide open.

Soon, an emotional exclamation spilled from his lips.

“Oh. Ohhh!”

Anyone watching him might have thought he had discovered a treasure island, but what appeared beyond the thick fog was simply an island.

It was neither small like the islands scattered along Korea’s Han River nor deserted, without any sign of human habitation.

“That over there… Could it be…?”

At Hyuk Mujin’s murmur, Gung Gibang nodded beside him.

“It’s a ferry landing. Looks like we came to the right place.”

The existence of a ferry landing where ships could dock meant, in other words, that people lived there—or that the island was frequently used as a stopover.

And everyone present already knew who had established their home in a place that could only be reached by crossing that insane Tianling Falls.

“Wow, Donghu Stronghold!”

Cheongpung’s shout broke the silence of the Yangtze and rang out across the water.

Jin Wikyung spoke, his expression stiff.

“By now, Donghu Stronghold must know we have arrived. It would be wise to prepare for any unforeseen developments.”

“…”

No one needed to ask what he meant.

If Donghu Stronghold really was responsible for the two incidents that had occurred over the past fifteen days, just as the circumstances revealed so far suggested… then a clash of martial force might take place, in accordance with the laws of Murim.

“Stronghold Lord. We did not come here to spill blood. I trust you understand what I mean.”

Mu Song had remained silent until now. He met Jin Wikyung’s gaze and answered.

“My subordinates and I took the lead in coming here to prove our League brothers’ innocence. If you persecute us without even hearing the full circumstances…”

“I can promise you that will not happen. Wudang and the Zhuge Clan have already guaranteed as much, and everyone present, myself included, will serve as a witness.”

After a brief hesitation, Mu Song gave a small nod.

“…I will trust you.”

Perhaps Mu Song was the person here most desperate to prevent bloodshed.

No matter how skilled the river bandits of Donghu Stronghold might be, and no matter how powerful their leader, Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung, was as a Supreme Peak master, they could not withstand our current force.

Even if some utterly incomprehensible disaster—a genuine one-in-ten-thousand chance—sent everyone here to the bottom of the Yangtze, the Yangtze River Channel League would then have to face the whole of Murim. If the Nine Sects and One Gang joined forces with the Five Great Families, the League would vanish without a trace.

“Raise the flag high and let them know we are here.”

The river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold immediately carried out their lord’s order.

Soon, the flag of the Yangtze River Channel League fluttered above the four swift ships, and seven low drumbeats echoed beyond the fog.

And then…

Nothing happened.

The Yangtze, the fog, and the quietly flowing water remained unchanged.

The only things that changed were the question on Jin Wikyung’s face and the wavering in Mu Song’s eyes.

“Stronghold Lord. What is happening?”

“I’m not sure, either. We definitely sent the signal, so a reply should have come…”

At that very moment—

“I’m afraid that will be difficult.”

Everyone turned toward the sudden voice.

Countless gazes fell upon the young medical apprentice whom no one had paid any attention to until now.

He continued in a clear, composed voice.

“It seems something has happened.”

“What do you mean…!”

Mu Song’s shout died unfinished.

The young medical apprentice, Mungyeong, raised a finger and pointed.

Something previously concealed by the fog and aquatic plants had floated into view.

It was someone’s corpse.

Chapter 449

From the moment they crossed the unnaturally powerful current of Tianling Falls and entered the territory of Donghu Stronghold, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song's heart had been beating faster and faster.

Uncle Hwang. I've come.

Hwang Chung, the Yangtze One Saber and Lord of Donghu Stronghold, was like a master to Mu Song. No—perhaps he was even more than that.

Mu Song's true master, the Seafaring King, was not an affectionate man, and their relationship was as dry and barren as sand.

When Mu Song was young, it had been Hwang Chung's warm advice and consideration that allowed him to endure his master's harsh scolding and grueling training.

I believe in you, Uncle. You're not the kind of man who would do such a thing.

Hwang Chung was more serious and thoughtful than anyone else in the Yangtze River Channel League.

There was no way a man like him would make the worst possible move by eliminating the Sea Serpent Society and the Dongting Fisherman in such a manner.

It was because of his unshakable faith in Hwang Chung that Mu Song had chosen to come here in person.

But despite that faith, his unease continued to swell with every passing moment.

Why is it so quiet?

The Hwang Chung he knew, the Yangtze One Saber, was thorough and cautious in everything he did. He would never neglect the stronghold's defenses simply because Tianling Falls protected it.

Donghu Stronghold was a natural fortress built on the Yangtze.

If unauthorized intruders crossed Tianling Falls, they would soon see a gorge several hundred zhang[2131] long, along with countless arrowheads waiting to greet them from above.

But…

We're already right in front of it. Why hasn't there been any reply?

Even after they raised the Yangtze River Channel League's flag and beat the drums to signal their arrival, the surroundings remained as quiet as before.

Mu Song's heart hammered against his ribs as he stared at the island shrouded in thick fog.

Something has gone wrong.

The thought flashed through his mind.

It was not long before his vague unease took shape.

[2131] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length equal to about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

“It seems something has happened.”

“What do you mean…!”

Mu Song turned toward the young medical apprentice Mungyeong, but the rest of his words died in his throat. He swallowed hard.

A moment later, alarm spread like wildfire among the people aboard the ships.

“Th-that’s…”

“A corpse! It’s a corpse!”

Everyone present was a martial artist accustomed to blood and death. They had seen enough corpses to be sick of them, but this time was different.

This was Donghu Stronghold. With the Sea Serpent Society’s key figures wiped out and the Dongting Fisherman all but confirmed dead, there should have been no one in Hubei Province capable of crossing the now even fiercer Tianling Falls to reach this place.

And yet a corpse had appeared out of nowhere.

Amid the commotion, Mu Song forced out a strained command.

“…Pull it aboard at once. We need to identify it.”

“Y-yes, sir!”

Before the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold could move, someone strode forward.

“Stand back.”

Fire King Jeok Cheongang had been raging only moments ago. Now he spoke in a low, somber voice as he extended one hand.

Powerful internal energy shot across the distance and seized the corpse submerged in the water.

Whoosh—thud!

The body landed heavily on the deck of the swift ship.

Half of its upper body was gone, and its face was bloated. Mu Song’s eyes widened the moment he saw it.

“This man…”

“Do you know him?”

Jin Taekyung strode over, and Mu Song nodded dazedly.

“Little Tide Demon Wang Pil. Uncle Hwang’s right-hand man and the Deputy Stronghold Lord of Donghu Stronghold.”

Donghu Stronghold ruled the Yangtze in Hubei Province. Naturally, the name and sobriquet of its Deputy Stronghold Lord—and the right-hand man of Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung—were widely known.

Ignoring the sighs that escaped at the name Little Tide Demon, Jin Taekyung stared at Mu Song with a stiff expression.

“The Deputy Stronghold Lord? Are you certain?”

“Without a doubt. The body is badly damaged, but not enough to keep me from recognizing his face.”

“…Damn it.”

Jin Taekyung’s expression hardened. So did the faces of everyone who understood what this meant.

The death of even an ordinary river bandit would have been ominous enough. But this was the Deputy Stronghold Lord of Donghu Stronghold, a Supreme Peak master of the Yangtze River Channel League whose name was renowned throughout Hubei Murim.

What this sequence of events meant was obvious.

Something has happened at Donghu Stronghold.

Jin Taekyung was the first to act on the thought that had flashed through all their minds.

Whoosh!

He crossed the deck at blinding speed, reached the stern of the swift ship, and thrust both arms out with all his strength.

Boom! Booooom!

The Scorching Yang Qi carried by the Flame Divine Palm evaporated the river water and propelled the swift ship forward.

Only then did the others recover from their shock and begin moving after him.

“Boatmen, return to your positions and take up the oars! Every second counts!”

“Tell the other ships! Send the signal at once!”

Boom, boom, boooom!

Urgent shouts and drumbeats shattered the silence.

Amid the chaos, Mu Song raised his head, his heart pounding harder and louder than the drums echoing around him.

And then—

“…!”

He saw it.

No—all of them saw it.

Beyond the fog parting before the bow of the swift ship lay a shattered ferry landing and countless corpses filling the river.

“What the fuck…!”

The curse burst from my mouth at full volume before I could stop it. But no one gave me a disapproving look or blamed me.

Maybe they were too overwhelmed to care. Or maybe I had simply said what they all wanted to say.

That was how horrific the scene before us was.

“This is a hellscape.”

“…How could this happen?”

Jeok Cheongang muttered in a grim, subdued voice, while the usually cheerful Cheongpung looked around with trembling eyes.

Everywhere he looked, there were collapsed houses and corpses.

The bodies we had seen around the ferry landing were only a fraction of the dead scattered across the island.

“C-Captain. Over there…”

“I know.”

I forced myself to ignore Hyuk Mujin, who was calling to me in a trembling voice.

I had already seen what he was pointing at. My teeth clenched before I even realized it.

Children and commoners who never learned martial arts.

Donghu Stronghold was not inhabited solely by river bandits.

They had brought their families and relatives to this safe, natural fortress, and the people who gathered here had formed a village of their own.

And…

They’re all dead.

Children who looked as though they had only just been weaned. Frail old people and women. Even the hundreds of river bandits who should have risked their lives to protect them.

Every single one of them was dead.

That was the conclusion my companions and I had reached after searching every corner of the island for more than half a day, along with the martial artists of Wudang and the Zhuge Clan and the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold under Mu Song.

And among those countless dead was one particular person.

“Uncle Hwang!”

Mu Song’s beastlike roar echoed from far away. Gung Gibang muttered in a heavy voice.

“Looks like he finally found him.”

Some people said that no human life was more valuable than another.

But that was not true. There was a difference in weight. A person’s death weighed differently depending on who they had been in life and what relationship they had shared with you.

For Mu Song, at least, Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung must have been such a person.

"The Family Head has ordered me to bring you to him at once."

At the words of the Zhuge Clan martial artist who came hurrying toward us, Jin Wikyung nodded.

"This concerns Great Hero Hwang, I presume."

"Yes. Great Hero Hwang's body was just found. However…"

"Let's go. We'll hear the rest directly from the Family Head."

We set off without another word.

Not to mourn Hwang Chung's death, but because even in death, the Yangtze One Saber was important enough to demand our immediate attention.

Jeok Cheongang was the only one among us who had known him, but grief was not the reason his expression had hardened, either.

"What do you think?"

The sudden Sound Transmission slipped into my ear. I slowed my steps and answered.

"The same as you, Old Master."

"You know what this old man is thinking?"

"You're thinking the same thing I am."

"I feel an urge to use the Flame Divine Palm."

"I've needed to piss for a while, too, but I've been holding it in. You should hold it in as well, Old Master. I'm still organizing my thoughts."

I calmly laid out what I had been considering over the past half a day.

"Donghu Stronghold is a natural fortress that can only be reached by crossing Tianling Falls. I don't know every detail of the situation here, but no ordinary force could dream of defeating the Supreme Peak master Hwang Chung and the river bandits under his command."

"Even a mongrel has the advantage in its own yard. To face men who have spent their entire lives on the Yangtze, you would need overwhelming strength."

Jeok Cheongang's Sound Transmission continued.

"The Yangtze One Saber in particular is a veritable water ghost. During the Great Faction War, he won overwhelming victories against the Demonic Cult in every battle fought on water. To wipe out Donghu Stronghold, the attackers would have needed at least twice its strength."

Twice the strength of Donghu Stronghold…

I had only realized it after coming here, but Donghu Stronghold was on a scale utterly incomparable to the other water strongholds.

The number of bodies discovered so far had already surpassed a thousand. In terms of size alone, it would not have been an exaggeration to call it a faction in its own right.

Mu Song said something like that before, too. Donghu Stronghold is the strongest water stronghold in the Yangtze River Channel League after its headquarters.

One look around was enough to understand why.

Everything had been shattered and destroyed, but this one water stronghold had once maintained a fleet of some fifty ships and built a settlement filled with houses that would not have looked out of place in a bustling city.

It might not have compared to prestigious great factions such as the Nine Sects and One Gang[2132] or the Five Great Families,[2133] but the river bandits under the Yangtze One Saber must have been formidable elites in their own right.

And very few groups could deploy twice that much force against Donghu Stronghold.

No—only a handful.

“If we’re talking about places capable of mobilizing that many men and ships…”

“As far as this old man knows, there are only four in Hubei Province. One of them is already as good as gone.”

“Wudang, the Zhuge Clan, the government, and the Sea Serpent Society. Correct?”

“Correct. But most of the Sea Serpent Society are fishermen and boatmen who banded together for their livelihoods, so they have far too few masters. Wudang and the Zhuge Clan have the strength, but neither has any reason or justification to attack Donghu Stronghold.”

“The government is the same.”

“Of course. Even a child knows that Murim and the authorities maintain a relationship of mutual noninterference. Even if the Son of Heaven[2134] had issued an imperial edict to subjugate the stronghold, it could never have been carried out this secretly, hidden from the eyes of the entire realm.”

Murim was a tree rooted deep within the forest of the world.

It had grown too tall to prune, and anyone who tried to chop it down carelessly risked damaging the blade of their own ax instead.

That was one of the reasons Murim had endured even though the owner of the forest had changed many times.

A towering tree that even the Son of Heaven,[2135] the woodcutter, could not easily raise his ax against.

[2132] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations.
[2133] The Five Great Families is a grouping of prominent martial-arts clans.
[2134] Son of Heaven is a traditional title for the Emperor.
[2135] Son of Heaven is a traditional title for the Emperor.

That was Murim. The countless branches and leaves that had sprung from this great tree had grown by joining forces—and, at times, by breaking one another.

The Yangtze River Channel League was one of the thicker branches.

If all the water strongholds scattered across the realm were gathered in one place, they would be a major force in their own right, and the number of masters among them would not fall far behind the Nine Sects and One Gang[2136] or the Five Great Families.[2137]

And now that very branch of the Yangtze River Channel League had been broken.

By someone whose identity remained unknown.

“Do you think the culprit is one of those four? Wudang, the Zhuge Clan, the authorities, or the Sea Serpent Society?”

“This waterway sees hundreds of ships pass through every day. Mobilizing enough force to cross Tianling Falls while avoiding all those eyes would be… extremely difficult.”

“It might have been extremely easy.”

I finally let out the words that had been hovering on the tip of my tongue.

“If it was Dark Heaven.”

“…!”

“They had no need to load hundreds or thousands of men onto ships and cross Tianling Falls. If a warp—no, if the formation they call a Moving Formation is hidden somewhere around here, that would explain everything.”

Dark Heaven had already proved it could be done in Shaolin and Sichuan.

If my guess was correct, it would also fully explain how they had gone unnoticed by the countless eyes traveling along the Yangtze.

Jeok Cheongang remained silent for a while before letting out a low groan.

“So this old man isn’t the only one who thinks so.”

“In a situation like this, we can’t rule out Dark Heaven. It stinks too damn much.”

“But why the Yangtze River Channel League?”

“I don’t know.”

I continued as I watched the familiar faces slowly approaching from the distance.

“That’s what we need to find out now.”

[2136] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major martial-arts organizations.

[2137] The Five Great Families is a grouping of prominent martial-arts clans.

Chapter 450

Several dozen people had gathered near the sandy shore at the far end of the island.

When the martial artists surrounding us opened a path, I finally spotted some familiar faces.

“Uncle Hwang! How could you leave your nephew behind? How could you!”

Mu Song wailed in a hoarse voice. Perfected Being Hyeongong of Wudang watched him with a sorrowful expression, while Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng watched with a profound, unreadable gaze.

And then…

Mungyeong.

Mungyeong usually faded into the background, barely making his presence felt among the others. But from the moment he realized something had happened at Donghu Stronghold, he had moved faster than anyone.

Not as the Slaughter Saint, but as a medical apprentice, he had rushed everywhere in an effort to save even a single life.

But as if to mock his efforts, there wasn’t a single survivor.

The corpse Mu Song clutched as he wept was merely one of the countless victims of the tragedy.

“You’ve arrived.”

Jeok Cheongang gave Zhuge Feng a displeased glance before speaking.

“Is that Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung?”

“It may be difficult to recognize him, but from what we’ve determined, there can be no doubt.”

That.

It might have sounded inappropriate to use such a word for the dead.

But anyone who saw Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung’s corpse in person would have found it hard to object. I was no different.

What kind of lunatic did this?

The corpse was so badly mutilated that it was difficult to believe it had once been a living person.

His face looked as if it had been pounded with a boulder, and there was simply nothing below his chest.

The stench of rotting flesh and entrails stabbed at my nose.

“Urgh—ugh!”

I couldn’t blame Hyuk Mujin for staggering backward with a retch.

Even my stomach churned, and I had seen more corpses and gruesome scenes than I could count.

The sworn brother of the Seafaring King. A Supreme Peak master who had ruled the vast Yangtze with his formidable martial arts.

Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung now looked more like a lump of meat than a corpse.

“Benefactor, this is…”

“It’s horrifying. What kind of godforsaken bastard would do this?”

Cheongpung and Gung Gibang murmured, their faces pale.

I stared at the corpse with my face stiff as stone, then suddenly felt something strange and opened my mouth.

“What are those corpses?”

The island was littered with bodies, so a few more were hardly surprising.

But the two corpses I had noticed were laid side by side next to Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung.

They must have been important, too.

Zhuge Feng followed my gaze and answered.

“Mad Water Saber Demon Hwang Cheol and Wave Fox Do Ripgun.”

“Mad Water Saber Demon… Wave Fox…”

I had heard those names a few times before, and fairly recently.

After a brief search of my memory, my head snapped up.

“Could they be…?”

“That’s right. They were the Stronghold Lords of Dangyang Stronghold and Honghu Stronghold, the two strongholds on Dongting Lake.”

“Weren’t they the ones who vanished without a trace after seizing the Sea Serpent Society’s territory?”

“Yes. They certainly were.”

Zhuge Feng continued, his deep gaze fixed on the bodies of the two Stronghold Lords.

“The Mad Water Saber Demon was hot-tempered, while the Wave Fox was cunning. That was why everyone had no choice but to suspect them when the Sea Serpent Society incident occurred a month ago.”

Gung Gibang suddenly spoke up.

“My Master once told me that only two people in the Yangtze River Channel League could keep the Mad Water Saber Demon and the Wave Fox under control.”

“That is correct. Whatever their personalities, both possessed formidable martial arts. Without a leash to restrain them, they would have run wild like vicious hounds.”

In that sense, Yangtze One Saber Hwang Chung would have made the perfect leash.

He was the second strongest master in the Yangtze River Channel League after the Seafaring King, and he must have been exceptionally skilled at handling people as well.

But the sturdy leash had snapped, and the two vicious hounds had also been found dead.

The Yangtze River Channel League's forces in Hubei Province, which had fought the Sea Serpent Society over local interests for years, had also been laid to waste.

And there was only one group that could commit such an act without reason or justification.

"Dark Heaven. Is it them again?"

Perfected Being Hyeongong's sigh carried unmistakable anger and sorrow.

After Henan and Sichuan, Dark Heaven's shadow had finally fallen over Hubei Province.

No—perhaps Dark Heaven had stood astride the world for a very long time.

Perhaps we simply had not felt its shadow because it had been night, with not a single ray of light.

Just as the Head Elder joined hands with Dark Heaven long ago.

This scheme hadn't begun yesterday or the day before. It had been taking shape since the time of the Great Faction War.

"An age of chaos. We have truly entered an age of chaos."

Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng muttered under his breath, then raised his head and looked around.

His eyes gleamed with an inscrutable light as he stared into the thick fog on every side.

It was as if he could see through it to something crouching beyond.

Everyone, including my companions and me, sprang into action.

But even after thoroughly searching the island and the surrounding cliffs for a single survivor or witness, we found nothing.

If anything, we were left with even more questions and frustration.

It's one thing for there to be no survivors, but how can there be no trace of a formation, either?

If Dark Heaven had reached this place through a Moving Formation instead of passing through Tianling Falls, traces like the ones we had found in Sichuan had to remain somewhere nearby.

Yet even after retainers of the Zhuge Clan, renowned for their knowledge of formations and mechanisms, joined the search, we had nothing to show for it.

Even Zhuge Feng eventually came to question me.

“Are you certain such a formation truly exists?”

“I told you, it does. We left Henan as soon as everything was over, so we couldn’t search for it there. But during the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, I saw it clearly with my own two eyes.”

“I knew of it from the letters I received, but no such bizarre formation exists in our family’s records.”

“Then this is your chance to add it.”

“…”

“It’s here somewhere. We have to find it.”

“I agree. But the people gathered here are not enough.”

The sheer size of the island Donghu Stronghold had made its headquarters was one problem, but the surrounding terrain was an even greater one.

Cliffs stretching hundreds of jang[2138] surrounded it on every side, making it impossible to approach by land, while an even greater expanse of river lay beyond them.

With only four swift ships and roughly three hundred people, there was a limit to how much we could search.

“It was a mistake to select people for their martial prowess. We should have brought retainers well versed in formations.”

Regretting it now wouldn’t change anything.

Zhuge Feng, myself, and everyone else here had been worried about a bloody clash with the Yangtze River Channel League. None of us had dreamed that this would be waiting for us.

“Then we’ll go to the Zhuge Clan and bring back the people we need.”

“It would be best if I went myself as Family Head, but under the circumstances, that appears to be our best option. I’ll assign several of our retainers to accompany you.”

Jeok Cheongang, who had been listening quietly, suddenly spoke to me.

“Does that ‘we’ of yours include this old man?”

“Of course. Don’t you know the saying? Wherever the needle goes, the thread follows.”

“I see. Then have you heard this saying?”

“…?”

“Talk bullshit and you die.”

“…!”

I flinched, and Jeok Cheongang clenched his fist menacingly.

“This old man isn’t going. If you want to go, go by yourself.”

[2138] A jang is ten traditional Korean ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“What, are you planning to live here for the rest of your life? Are you never leaving?”

“Who said this old man would stay forever? There’s no need for everyone to rush off together. If even one more person remains behind to help search for the formation, we can uncover the culprit and restore peace to Hubei, can’t we?”

Ever since his friend, the Dharma King Hong Dao, had been killed by Dark Heaven, Jeok Cheongang had ground his teeth at the mere mention of its name. Yet something about his reaction this time didn’t add up.

After thinking for a moment, I clapped my hands.

“Ah. Now I get it. It’s because of Tianling Falls.”

“…!”

“You should have just said so instead of beating around the bush. I forgot to take that into account, too.”

“W-who says I care about a little water? Have you forgotten who this old man is?”

“Hmm. A Coward?”

“You little—!”

Bam! Bam! Baaam!

After taking about seven blows to the back of the head, I fled and headed toward my next destination.

The familiar faces gathered nearby turned toward me.

“Captain. What do we do now?”

I gave Hyuk Mujin a light kick in the butt as I answered.

“I just talked it over with them. We have to leave immediately, so get ready.”

“Leave? Where are we going?”

“The Zhuge Clan. It seems we need to bring back people skilled in formations and mechanisms. If necessary, we’ll also bring in reinforcements from Wudang. I heard they have several Daoists who are well versed in formations.”

“Wudang might be difficult.”

I frowned at Gung Gibang’s sudden interruption.

“What kind of bullshit is that?”

“I’m not the one who said it. Perfected Being Hyeongong did.”

“Hmm. Now that I think about it, he must have had a good reason.”

“…”

“Whatever. Explain. What do you mean?”

“It seems Wudang has troubles of its own. Even before the Sea Serpent Society incident, some madman they’re calling the Killing Ghost had been murdering people throughout Hubei Province… Apparently, the situation has grown serious. More than thirty people have already died by his hand, so I suppose that’s no surprise.”

“The Killing Ghost? Is he a martial artist?”

“He certainly seems to be a martial artist of considerable skill. Most of his victims were commoners, but a fairly renowned First Rate wandering martial artist was reportedly found dead after accepting a government commission to hunt him down.”

A First Rate wandering martial artist would be considered a First Rate master wherever he went.

If the rumored Killing Ghost had truly disposed of one with ease and escaped, there was a good chance he was a Peak master.

Still, Wudang wouldn’t mobilize the entire sect just to catch one man.

The question vanished at Gung Gibang’s next words.

“Was it three days ago? Twenty pilgrims climbing Mount Wudang were massacred. Among them were children of high officials and nobles who intended to enter Wudang as lay disciples.”

“Ah.”

This hadn’t happened just anywhere. The massacre had taken place on Mount Wudang itself.

As if pilgrims being massacred right in Wudang’s own front yard weren’t enough, the victims included children of high officials and nobles. Wudang’s fury was only natural.

He’s completely insane. Bold, too.

For a moment, the words *Dark Heaven* crossed my mind, but I soon shook my head.

This was Murim. It was full of lunatics who made modern serial killers look like amateurs.

Even if someone were murdered in broad daylight on a main road, it would not be all that surprising.

If Dark Heaven had done this, an incident incomparably larger would have erupted.

In any case, that was Wudang’s situation. We could reconsider the matter after reaching the Zhuge Clan.

“Well, now that I know, everyone pack your things. They’re already preparing outside to take us back.”

Jin Wikyung had already decided to remain behind before I went to meet Zhuge Feng, so I only needed to bring the people gathered here.

But one bastard—or rather, one gentleman—seemed to have other ideas.

“I’ll stay.”

“Which bastard— Oh. It’s Mungyeong.”

“Is there any reason I need to accompany you?”

“Nope. Stay. Stay.”

Please stay.

Chapter 451

“Benefactor, where are you going?”

“Huh?”

I flinched as I quietly edged toward the door. Cheongpung, who had gathered up his belongings, tilted his head at me.

“What? Why?”

“Are you going somewhere?”

“I, uh… something urgent came up.”

“You said we had to leave right away.”

“Listen, Young Hero Cheong. I wasn’t going to go into this, but…”

I deliberately hardened my expression.

“I’m going to relieve myself. Happy?”

“But the privy isn’t in that direction.”

“…”

He was annoyingly sharp.

Martial arts were his minor, while eating and shitting were his major. He had to know the location of every privy on the island.

After a moment’s hesitation, I answered.

“…I’m going to piss outside.”

Even I had to admit it was a desperate excuse.

Only then did Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin realize something was off. They stopped packing their bags and turned toward me.

“Young Hero Gung, doesn’t the Captain seem unusually talkative today?”

“Yeah. Why does he look so restless?”

“That’s because I’m trying to decide which of you two to hit first.”

Normally, they would have backed down the moment I said something like that. But after being thoroughly conditioned by my violence, the two of them had grown considerably.

“Hmm. If this were our usual Captain, his hands would have moved before his words. But he’s trying to talk his way out of it? There’s definitely something going on.”

“Right?”

“Absolutely. Do you think I’ve only been beaten once or twice? There’s a logic and flow to these things.”

As Hyuk Mujin stared at me through narrowed eyes, Gung Gibang’s eyes suddenly widened, and he glanced around.

“Wait. Where did Mungyeong go?”

"Oh, you're right. He was here a moment ago. Where the hell did he go?"

Where else? He was already outside waiting for me.

Let's talk.

I sighed as I recalled the Sound Transmission Mungyeong had sent me earlier.

Denying it any longer would only make them more suspicious.

"He's outside. We have something to discuss in private."

"In the privy? Just the two of you?"

"…What the hell are you talking about, you lunatic? You're making it sound suggestive."

Hyuk Mujin gave me a dubious look.

"Captain, I've already been conditioned to insults and violence, so I'll be fine. But please don't expose Mungyeong to any strange influences."

"…"

What the hell was this lunatic talking about? I was the one about to end up covered in blood.

I was too dumbfounded to speak, and Gung Gibang added his two cents.

"Hyuk's right. The more I see that kid, the more thoughtful and kind he seems. Don't pick on him for no reason."

"Wow. You bastards, seriously…"

I stopped myself.

"Forget it. What would you two know?"

Cheongpung had at least finally noticed what was going on and kept his mouth shut like a mute with honey in it…

No, now that I looked closer, he really was stuffing candy into his mouth.

Where does he keep getting that candy?

If I stayed here any longer, I was going to lose my mind.

Shaking my head, I ignored the voices behind me and left the house.

Outside, Mungyeong stood waiting in the courtyard, dressed in spotless white robes.

"You're late."

"It didn't take that long…"

"You're late."

"Sorry…"

"You're late."

"…"

Please save me.

The pressure of that broken-record routine was no joke. His aura bore down on me so subtly that no one else could detect it, and I swallowed hard.

“S-sorry I’m late. But what’s going on?”

“Pardon?”

“Huh?”

“What do you mean? You called me out earlier because you had something to say.”

Had Cannes named him Actor of the Year or something?

He blinked as if he truly had no idea what I was talking about. For a moment, even I nearly fell for it.

The monster wearing the skin of a young medical apprentice smiled brightly and continued.

“Oh, you want us to move somewhere else for a moment? Understood.”

“No. If possible, I think it would be better to talk right here…”

“Oh, you want us to move somewhere else for a moment? Understood.”

“…Fine. Let’s go.”

I miss my mother.

Holding back tears, I followed Mungyeong.

We avoided the occasional disciples of the Zhuge Clan and Wudang, along with the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold, until we reached a deserted area. Only then did Mungyeong finally speak.

“Dark Heaven. Was this their doing?”

“Yeah. It looks that way.”

“There’s no one here.”

I corrected myself at the speed of light.

“It appears so, sir.”

“So it is not certain yet.”

“There is always some possibility of error. But although we haven’t found the formation, I’m convinced Dark Heaven was responsible.”

“Dark Heaven. Dark Heaven…”

Mungyeong muttered the words under his breath, then suddenly raised his head.

He silently gazed at the dark night sky, where even the full moon had hidden itself. After a moment, he abruptly asked, “Did you notice anything strange about the corpses?”

“Something strange?”

“The wounds left on them.”

Every death left traces. This was especially true of deaths caused by battles between martial artists.

I had heard that a widely experienced master with a deep understanding of various martial arts could identify the weapon used—and even determine which form had killed the victim—simply by examining the wounds on a corpse.

And the young medical apprentice before me possessed both the discernment and martial prowess to make him one of the finest examiners of the dead in Murim.

"I have never seen wounds like these before. They seem to follow the principles of the very basic Three Calamities Sword Technique, yet they undulate like waves. They are exceedingly strange."

Mungyeong slowly raised one hand and swept it through the air. Thread-thin strands of internal energy flowed from it, glowing faintly in the darkness.

"If I had to guess, the culprit did not use an ordinary weapon. It was an unusual weapon with a winding blade, something akin to a Snake Sword."

"I thought they'd been cut with Force."

"Your guess is correct. It was Force—or something every bit as sharp."

The only thing as sharp as Force was Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

And no matter how thoroughly Dark Heaven had prepared, there was no way so many of its forces could have been armed with weapons made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

No matter how much gold you have, Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron is difficult to obtain.

This was not a question of capital. It was a question of resource scarcity.

As I stood lost in thought, Mungyeong asked, "Did you examine all the corpses?"

"Not all of them. I looked at the ones that stood out. I'm not particularly knowledgeable, so even after examining them myself, I couldn't tell which martial arts or forms had been used."

"One of the corpses you examined belonged to Hwang Chung, the Yangtze One Saber. What did you make of it?"

"He'd been cut cleanly in two at the waist by Force. But the decay was so severe that I couldn't determine anything beyond that…"

"And the Mad Water Saber Demon and the Wave Fox?"

"Those two…"

I suddenly frowned.

A detail shared by all three corpses had just occurred to me.

…Only their upper bodies remained.

The lower halves of all three corpses were nowhere to be found.

I had seen several other corpses like that, so it had not struck me as strange at the time. Now that I thought about it, though, it was certainly suspicious.

"Didn't the fish eat them?"

"That would not be entirely wrong. From what I determined, the massacre at Donghu Stronghold took place ten days ago. The cold has been gone for some time, so severe decay is only natural. The corpses submerged in water would have fared even worse."

Warm sunlight and damp air had erased many of the traces left behind by death.

But they had not erased everything.

“By comparison, the commoners’ corpses still had their limbs relatively intact. Did you notice that?”

“Yes. Those who hadn’t learned martial arts weren’t cut apart. They were crushed.”

Unlike the corpses of the river bandits, the bodies of the children, women, and elderly had not been severed. Their entire bodies had simply been crushed and pulverized.

And there was one more thing.

“The houses and the surrounding ground had caved in everywhere. That would have been impossible without a force of ten thousand geun,[2139] and it is not a method an internal-arts master with profound internal energy would choose.”

“So, an external-arts master?”

“There’s no one here, remember?”

“…I was just talking to myself.”

He was awfully sensitive about this.

After hurriedly making that excuse, I fell silent and considered the matter.

Martial arts in Murim could broadly be divided into two categories.

Internal arts emphasized the efficient use and application of internal energy. External arts also used internal energy, but focused on tempering the body to their absolute limits.

Most people faced those two paths upon entering the world of martial arts, and most chose the former.

Partly because training in external arts was excruciating, but also because achieving any meaningful results required long years of grueling perseverance.

Which means there are only a handful of Supreme Peak external-arts masters capable of this level of destruction.

There were hardly any Supreme Peak masters in the world to begin with, even if you turned the whole realm upside down and shook it out.

I glanced at Mungyeong, silently asking for an answer. A faint crease appeared on the young medical apprentice’s smooth forehead.

“Looking at me will do you no good. I do not know his identity either. No—I should say their identities, not his.”

“There are two?”

“At least two. Three at most.”

“Three Supreme Peak masters…”

[2139] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

“Based on my guess, they are even more formidable than the Qilian Three Fiends we faced in Sichuan. At least one of them uses an unusual weapon.”

For fuck’s sake. This isn’t some five-star establishment. Why are there three Supreme Peak masters?

It was only because Mungyeong and Jeok Cheongang were holding down the fort that I could afford to leave at all. Without them here, I would have been too worried about what might happen to go anywhere.

“With this much information, the Third Fiend might know something. He must have at least heard who his comrades were.”

The Third Fiend we had captured in Sichuan was one of the reasons I was going to the Zhuge Clan.

I had heard that he had become like a bipolar patient after his balls were crushed, but if I worked him over with enough care and dedication, he would not last long.

Maybe we can even put him out front and have him lead us to the formation.

That hopeful thought had barely crossed my mind when Mungyeong spoke.

“Perhaps it is someone everyone already knows.”

“What?”

“I mean the one who uses that unusual weapon.”

It took me quite a while to grasp what he meant.

The realization struck like a hammer to the back of my head.

I stared blankly at Mungyeong.

“Are you serious?”

“A seasoned Supreme Peak master. Forms and wounds so unusual that they are difficult to read. There cannot be many people at that realm who wield such a weapon.”

“Then it really is…”

A dry voice emerged from between Mungyeong’s lips.

“The Dongting Fisherman. For now, he is the most likely suspect.”

“…!”

The eccentric master who had never left the area around Dongting Lake in his entire life.

Unusually, he used a fishing rod made of black wood as his signature weapon. He was a Supreme Peak master who had crossed Tianling Falls and disappeared after becoming enraged by the tragic news concerning his friend, the head of the Sea Serpent Society.

Everything fits perfectly.

I had forgotten for a moment.

I had forgotten about his existence.

This was no baseless suspicion.

Unlike the others, the Dongting Fisherman's corpse had never been found. The only trace he had left behind was his broken black-wood fishing rod.

It was only a guess, but what if the Dongting Fisherman really was a member of Dark Heaven?

"But the Dongting Fisherman Zhuge Feng told me about had absolutely no reason to do something like this…"

"Everything has a reason. The Dongting Fisherman is only human. He must have had a shadow he showed no one. Zhuge Feng is likely suspicious of him by now as well."

Mungyeong turned away, his voice cold.

"Always be suspicious, and stay alert. May martial fortune be with you."

Chapter 452

Unlike the journey in, the way out wasn't as difficult as I'd expected.

Part of that was because the whirlpools of Tianling Falls mostly spiraled outward. It also helped that the veteran river bandits from Water Dragon Stronghold, who had spent years working aboard ships, were making full use of their skills.

"Turn to port!"

"Starboard! Don't row until the signal!"

"More, more, more… Now!"

"Yaaah!"

Whoooosh! Splash!

"The boat—the boat's tilting!"

"Great Hero Jin!"

"Help us!"

"…Damn it, you bastards."

Come to think of it, maybe it was a little difficult after all.

Still, it was nothing we couldn't handle. Even without powerful allies like Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong, Cheongpung and I could overcome most crises if we stepped in.

The first time is hard. Why would the second be?

The river bandits weren't the only ones who had grown accustomed to the violent whirlpools of Tianling Falls. I had prepared in advance as well, and thrust both palms forward with all my strength.

Boom!

The tilting swift ship regained its balance. Now it was time to pick up speed and escape this damned whirlpool.

I called out to the man I had stationed at the stern for precisely this situation.

"Cheongpung, now!"

"Yee-haw!"

"You crazy bastard! Stop hanging there and playing around!"

"Oh, sorry, Benefactor. I didn't mean to. Before I knew it…"

"Just hurry up and do it!"

"Yes!"

Boom, boom, boom!

Cheongpung was about as far from normal as a person could get, but his skills were undeniable.

Dozens of palm shadows infused with powerful internal energy struck through the air and lashed the surface of the water. The resulting thrust sent the swift ship vaulting over the whirlpool of Tianling Falls before landing on the other side.

Boom! Splash!

A towering spray engulfed the hull. Drenched from head to toe in river water, Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin muttered under their breath.

“Damn it. Last time we got dunked, and now we’re getting drenched. We really do get everything.”

“I swear, once this is over, I’m never coming back to the Yangtze. Not ever. Every day feels like living the life of a goddamn beggar.”

“…Are you picking a fight with me?”

“No. Honestly, doesn’t it feel like we’re living as beggars?”

“That’s true. It pisses me off, but you’re right. You’re right, and it still pisses me off.”

“Damn. I really do feel like a beggar.”

“…I get it, so shut up.”

Those two acted like this every chance they got.

Leaving behind the bickering of our two human pieces of sweet-and-sour pork—dunked on the way in and drenched on the way out—the swift ship cleared Tianling Falls safely and sped across the Yangtze.

About three shichen[2140] later, the ship that had departed at dawn reached the ferry landing at Zaoyang. By then, it was already close to noon.

“The waterways of the Yangtze do not reach Mount Longzhong, where the Zhuge Clan is located. From here, you will have to travel by land.”

The deputy Stronghold Lord of Water Dragon Stronghold had come in Mu Song’s place. I nodded at his explanation.

Hubei Province had highly developed land and water transportation, but that didn’t mean every tributary of the Yangtze was connected. A boat couldn’t travel where there was no water.

It’s not like these people are Vikings.[2141]

Fortunately, the broad, level highways were well maintained. We could reach our destination quickly by carriage or by using movement techniques.

Zaoyang and Mount Longzhong were relatively close, so the journey shouldn’t take long.

The Zhuge Clan retainer whom Zhuge Feng had ordered to accompany us wasn’t standing around idle, either.

[2140] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.

[2141] The Vikings were known for hauling their longships overland between rivers and lakes, a practice called portaging.

“I will send word to the Zaoyang branch immediately and have carriages prepared. Relay stations have been established all along the main roads, so if we change carriages along the way, we will reach our family home in no time.”

“Oh, right.”

The Zhuge Clan was a prestigious major faction that divided control of Hubei Province with Wudang.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had also established branches and sub-branches throughout Shanxi Province to solidify its control over the region. The Zhuge Clan’s network was probably even more extensive.

It’s like a major brand opening chain stores.

Then we should arrive in half a day at the latest.

I had just stepped off the ship after roughly calculating the travel time in my head when—

Clack, clack, clack.

A group appeared to the sound of perfectly synchronized footsteps and surrounded the ferry landing.

I frowned as I stared at the unwelcome guests.

What is this now?

There were nearly thirty martial artists.

Every one of them wore a lustrous blue silk martial uniform and carried a high-quality steel longsword at their waist. Hyuk Mujin’s eyes widened.

“That’s…”

“What? Do you know them?”

“No. I was just surprised by those silk uniforms.”

“What?”

“That’s Shu brocade from Sichuan. It’s considered one of the finest silks under heaven. My father dreamed of filling an entire warehouse with it. That’s how expensive and precious it is… And they made martial uniforms out of it. I don’t know who their employer is, but they must be loaded.”

“…”

I’d told the bastard to identify them, and he was evaluating the quality of their silk instead.

As I stared at him in disbelief, Gung Gibang clicked his tongue and cut in.

“I can’t tell whether that bastard is a martial artist or a cloth merchant. Don’t expect anything from that Hyuk brat. Ask this elder instead.”

“I don’t know about making you an elder, but I can make you a cripple. Tell us before my fist gets there.”

“…They’re martial artists from Qingxia Hall. I told you, so please loosen that fist a little.”

"Qingxia Hall? What do those bastards do?"

Gung Gibang glanced at my still-clenched fist and answered.

"They aren't an official sect, but they wield considerable influence in Hubei Province in various ways."

"They look pretty pathetic for people with that kind of influence."

I glanced at the martial artists standing in formation in the distance.

They wore uniforms made of expensive Shu brocade and carried quality swords, but that was all.

Most were Second or Third Rate swordsmen who fell short of First Rate. Perhaps they cared more about their appearance than their martial arts, because every one of them was well built and handsome.

They're even wearing makeup.

At this point, weren't they idols rather than martial artists?

It almost made me wonder if the K-pop craze that had begun in Korea had crossed worlds and spread all the way to Murim.

Qingxia Bulletproof Martial Artist Corps. Maybe they had come to play a gig under a name like that.

"Those guys' group name—or rather, their organization's name—was Qingxia Hall, right? They're actually a big deal in Hubei?"

"I've heard they throw considerable weight around."

"They look like they'd piss themselves the moment a real fight started…"

Did Hubei decide its sect rankings through popularity votes?

While I was seriously pondering the question, the Zhuge Clan retainer spoke.

"Qingxia Hall is a sort of social club."

"A social club?"

"Yes. It was formed by the sons and daughters of influential people with varying degrees of power throughout Hubei Province. They are always running around together and causing all kinds of trouble, but they have such powerful backing that matters usually fizzle out without consequence."

"Oh. A gold-spoon club."

"I'm sorry, what did you say?"

"Nothing important. In that case, we can just continue on our way."

So that was all they were. A noisy empty cart decked out in gaudy finery.

Pathetic people like that could be found anywhere. Having lost interest in Qingxia Hall, I took the lead and started walking.

"Which way do we go to reach the Zaoyang branch?"

"It will take less than fifteen minutes from here. First, we should head to the main road over there…"

The Zhuge Clan retainer trailed off.

An extravagantly luxurious procession was approaching from the main road he had just indicated—more lavish than anything I had ever seen.

“The heroes of Qingxia Hall are passing through!”

At the shrill cry of a middle-aged man with weasel whiskers, musicians walking along both sides of the procession began to play. Beautiful women scattered flower petals through the air.

The main road was instantly swept up in a festive atmosphere.

The commoners traveling along it watched the procession with expressions mingling anticipation and discontent.

Their countless gazes converged on ten young men and women riding in four-bearer palanquins carved with dragons and phoenixes.

Wreathed in the easy smiles only the rich could afford, they looked down at the poorly dressed commoners and tossed something from their hands.

Clatter, clatter, clatter!

Not hidden weapons… money. Gleaming silver nyang, each worth a hundred iron coins.

Only then did I understand the anticipation on the commoners’ faces.

“Waaah!”

“Silver nyang! It’s silver!”

“Jang-pal, you vile bastard! How dare you try to snatch someone else’s silver nyang? Take your hand off it right now!”

“Bullshit. Didn’t you see my hand get there first?”

“You fucking son of a—!”

Cheers and curses rose over the ceaselessly falling petals and silver nyang.

A woman bit into her unexpected windfall to test it. Men loudly insisted that they were the rightful owners, then promptly began fighting over it.

Meanwhile, the young men and women in the palanquins laughed as they watched the spectacle.

“What a complete shitshow.”

The sight made me shake my head.

The rich kids scattering money and enjoying the people’s reactions as if they were watching a circus looked pathetic. The sight of the commoners fighting tooth and nail for a single silver nyang left a bitter taste in my mouth and made me feel sorry for them.

But it had nothing to do with me.

“Forget about that. Let’s just get going…”

I trailed off and blinked.

What the hell was this?

Gone.

The bastards who had been beside me moments ago were nowhere to be seen. Only the Zhuge Clan retainer remained, standing there awkwardly.

“Wait, where did every one of those bastards go?”

The retainer hesitated, then raised a hand and pointed in one direction.

“They’re over there.”

“…?”

I turned my head and was rendered speechless.

Whoosh, whoosh-whoosh!

“No! You can’t!”

“My silver!”

One person was darting through the crowd with ghostlike movements, snatching silver nyang out of the air.

No. Not one person.

One fucking beggar.

The Myriad-Li[2142] Chasing Wind Movement Technique?

That lunatic was actually using a secret technique of the Beggars’ Sect for this?

He was faster and more agile than I had ever seen him. He had complained endlessly that he’d only mastered the technique to the fifth stage, yet the movements he was displaying now were at least seventh-stage.

That bastard is single-handedly disgracing the Beggars’ Sect.

Even for a beggar, how could he be this devoted to his calling?

But I had no time to worry about another sect’s reputation. The Jin Family of Taiyuan’s own dark horse was no less impressive.

“Haap!”

Whoosh! Rat-a-tat-tat!

Hyuk Mujin kicked off the ground and soared into the air, swinging his sword. The silver nyang caught in its powerful, fluid arc popped into the air, then showered down onto the flat of his blade.

Hyuk Mujin’s face lit up when he checked the silver.

“Wow! Ten silver nyang!”

“…”

That bastard had ten hits coming. Guaranteed.

I swallowed the curses rising to my throat and searched for the last remaining person.

Where is that Cheongpung bastard?

[2142] Li is a traditional Chinese distance unit of approximately 500 m (0.311 mi). Here it is part of the technique’s name.

Unlike Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin, who were scooping up silver nyang with all their might, Cheongpung was nowhere to be seen.

But I knew the habits of the creature called Cheongpung inside and out, so it didn't take me long to find him.

"First, ten sweets, please. Oh, and some jeonbyeong[2143] too. Not the ones you just picked up—the big ones over there, and give me plenty. Wow, thank you! By any chance, where's the dumpling shop?"

Snap.

Something inside my head broke. My eyes rolled back until only the whites showed, and I roared.

"You fucking bastards!"

[2143] Jeonbyeong is a Korean thin pancake or crepe.

Chapter 453

“You fucking baaaastards!”

For a moment, it felt as though a cold wind had swept through.

Or maybe my shout had simply been loud enough to feel like one.

Probably the latter.

Whoooosh.

Dozens of people who had been scrambling for silver nyang[2144] froze, and silence fell over the noisy main road.

Then one short command broke the stillness.

“I’m counting to three.”

“…?”

“Fall in.”

“…!”

Give a dog three years at a village school and it can recite poetry. Beat it for long enough and it can memorize the Four Books and Three Classics.[2145]

That was why the village-school dog—or rather, Hyuk Mujin—who had been conditioned by a year of my violence and profanity moved faster than anyone else.

“Faaall iiiin!”

Screaming his acknowledgment, Hyuk Mujin came running and stopped dead in front of me.

A beat later, Gung Gibang grasped the situation and used his movement technique, arriving almost simultaneously with Hyuk Mujin. As for Cheongpung…

“Pancakes! Please give me the pancakes, quick! Benefactor is angry!”

That sibu-leol[2146] bastard. He was still making sure to get his snacks.

Once they had been wrapped, Cheongpung raced toward me like a streak of light. I spoke to him gently.

“Take your time. I’m not angry.”

“Wow! Really?”

“Yeah. I’m not angry. I’m fucking pissed.”

“Ah, ah…”

I looked at the fidgeting Cheongpung and the other two, who were subtly avoiding my gaze.

When the hell are these bastards going to become human?

[2144] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; the money here is silver.

[2145] The Four Books and Three Classics are foundational texts of Confucian learning.

[2146] *Sibu-leol* is a Korean profanity, roughly equivalent to “fuck.”

They should have been squeezing out every last ounce of strength to reach the Zhuge Clan, yet here they were using martial arts to pick up a few silver nyang.[2147]

Gung Gibang had even sneakily snatched silver nyang[2148] out of someone else's hand. At this point, he was not a beggar. He was a bandit.

Life, for fuck's sake…

I'd gone to such lengths lately to improve employee benefits, and this was what I got.

I looked up at the clear sky and spat into my palm.

"Hyuk Mujin. Stick out your forehead."

"Pardon?"

Hyuk Mujin jerked his head up, looking incredulous.

"Just me?"

"Yeah. You first."

"What about Gung Gibang?"

"He's a beggar down to the bone. Honestly, it's hard to criticize a beggar for picking up silver nyang."[2149]

"An accurate and wise judgment."

Gung Gibang, who had been watching my mood, cut in with a solemn voice. Hyuk Mujin opened his round eyes.

"No, what do you mean, 'hard to criticize'? You get angry every time I call you a beggar."

"Me? What nonsense. I'm a beggar from head to toe. I was born a beggar, and I'll live as one until the day I die."

"…You really are a beggar."

"Thank you for the compliment."

"Gung Gibang, you beggar bastard."

"Ah, how sweet."

After glaring at Gung Gibang as if he wanted to kill him, Hyuk Mujin spoke again.

"What about Cheongpung?"

"Cheongpung is Cheongpung."

Huashan or whatever, Cheongpung had always been like that.

That one sentence said it all. Hyuk Mujin muttered,

"That makes no sense, but somehow I understand…"

"People are watching. Let's get this over with."

"How many?"

"You tell me. How many blows will it take for you to reflect on your actions?"

[2147] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; the money here is silver.
[2148] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; the money here is silver.
[2149] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; the money here is silver.

“Then… one?”

“Three.”

“Damn it. Understood.”

“You cursed, so five.”

“…Just hit me ten times. Beat me to death.”

“Bonus points for such resolve, worthy of a martial artist. So, one blow. How many?”

“One!”

Hyuk Mujin shouted his reply with all his might and thrust his forehead forward.

That was when it happened.

“You there. Stop.”

“…?”

I lowered my hand and turned around.

The main road had gone deathly silent. Ten men and women seated in four-bearer palanquins were staring at us with a mixture of displeasure and interest.

All of them wore lavish clothing that flaunted their immense wealth, but one young man stood out in particular.

He was the one who had just spoken.

“I stopped. Why?”

The young man’s eyes widened at my question. He blinked for a while, as if unable to believe what he had heard, then let out a quiet laugh.

“It seems you do not know who this Young Master is.”

“Do I need to?”

“What an arrogant bastard!”

The young man wasn’t the one who said that.

I watched as a man kicked off from one of the palanquins and shot into the air.

What’s this now?

Whoosh, clang!

The sparrow-eyed man performed three somersaults in midair before landing and drawing his sword, his eyes blazing with fury.

The onlookers gasped at the flashy display.

“You appear to be a wandering martial artist, but as if causing a disturbance in broad daylight were not enough, you dare address a person of noble standing with such insolence—”

“You’ve got a lot of jewels on that thing. Are they supposed to distract people?”

I stared at the jewels decorating his sword. Dozens of gems in a variety of colors were shining in the sunlight.

“What?”

“It’s dazzling. Put it away.”

Clang!

The sparrow-eyed man’s eyes widened.

Unable to withstand the force of my finger flick, the sword flew from his hand and buried itself deep in the ground.

“Who the fuck points a sword at someone like that? In broad daylight, no less.”

Oh, look at him throwing a fit.

He was probably somewhere around First Rate.

He seemed to have polished his skills to a decent level, but he was an extreme poseur obsessed with appearances.

“T-this bastard…!”

“And you were the ones making all the noise. I just quieted things down. Don’t make this any more complicated than it needs to be. Just leave, all right?”

I meant it.

It wasn’t as if I’d never had a fly or two buzzing around me before. This wasn’t my home, and I was only passing through. There was no reason to spray insecticide on every mosquito that came at me.

Better to wave them away and keep going.

But no matter how sincerely you tried to explain something, there were always people who failed to understand the first time.

Shing, shing-shing!

Dozens of sword blades flashed from every direction. Martial artists from Qingxia Hall, dressed in blue silk martial uniforms, surrounded us in layer after layer. The sparrow-eyed man’s earlier panic gave way to smug satisfaction.

“You seem to be a fairly well-known wandering martial artist. Kneel and beg forgiveness while you still can. Who knows? Perhaps the Young Master will mercifully spare you.”

I glanced over the sparrow-eyed man’s shoulder. Led by the young man who appeared to be their leader, the others were watching us with sparkling eyes.

They looked exactly like zoo visitors watching monkeys.

“I don’t think the people over there are feeling particularly merciful.”

“What?”

“Of course, neither am I. And from what I’ve learned, this is the most effective medicine. Isn’t that right?”

I slowly raised my fist, and the Bermuda Triangle, which had been watching only my expression, responded enthusiastically.

“Exactly. They won’t come to their senses until they’ve been beaten like dogs on

the hottest day of summer."[2150]

"I was the first one to take that medicine. Cured me on the spot."

"Benefactor, can I go buy dumplings while you do that?"

"No. Stay there. This'll be over soon anyway."

Step.

"W-wait!"

The moment I stepped forward, panic filled the sparrow-eyed man's eyes.

A Third Rate thug would charge in out of sheer stubbornness because he would not know his opponent's level. But that man was a martial artist who had learned martial arts to a certain degree.

He had clearly realized that neither he nor the Qingxia Hall martial artists serving as an ornamental backdrop were any match for me.

"W-we're Qingxia Hall!"

"Oh. So?"

"H-have you never heard of Qingxia Hall's reputation?"

"Nope. My hearing hasn't been too good lately."

Step.

"Stop! I said stop!"

"Ahem."

By then, the sparrow-eyed man wasn't the only one getting desperate.

The Zhuge Clan retainer, who had been clicking his tongue as he watched, cleared his throat and spoke.

"I will explain the situation, so perhaps it would be best if you stopped…"

Whack! Thud!

"Pardon me? What did you just say?"

"…"

The Zhuge Clan retainer looked back and forth between me, standing there with my fist clenched, and the sparrow-eyed man, who lay unconscious with his nose crushed.

He muttered awkwardly,

"I said it might be best if you stopped…"

"Pardon?"

"There may be various complications…"

"Pardon?"

"It would be better to avoid any unnecessary conflict…"

"What was that?"

[2150] *Boknal* are the hottest days of the Korean summer, historically associated with eating dog-meat soup.

"…Never mind."

"Ah. All right."

I wiped the blood from my fist on my trouser leg and looked around.

Gung Gibang was muttering that he'd known the man would end up like that, while Hyuk Mujin beamed at his unexpected reprieve.

And Cheongpung…

"Hey! Where do you think you're going?"

"Gasp! Benefactor!"

Was that bastard seriously trying to buy dumplings right now…?

Cheongpung was silently inching away. Watching his retreating back, I began to wonder if he was really human.

I'm definitely catching that bastard.

I stepped forward with grim resolve. The ornamental guards surrounding us sucked in their breaths and moved aside.

But they weren't the only Qingxia Hall martial artists present.

"Ha-ha-ha! How amusing. Truly amusing. Don't you agree?"

At the young man's laughing question, the four huge men carrying his palanquin answered in unison.

"Yes, my lord."

"We cannot send off the benefactor who gave this Young Master such a good laugh. I am fine, so go and bring him here."

"Loyalty!"

Their shout rang with internal energy. The huge men set down the palanquin and charged toward me with the speed of the wind.

They had transformed from mere sedan bearers into outstanding Peak masters, attacking while covering all four directions.

Whoooooosh!

Each threw a punch carrying fierce qi, the four strikes interlocking with exquisite precision.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

With exactly four sounds of impact, four bodies sprawled face-first onto the ground at the same speed with which they had charged.

None of them got back up.

"What the sibu-leol?"[2151]

"…!"

"…!"

"…!"

[2151] *Sibu-leol* is a Korean profanity, roughly equivalent to "fuck."

Complete silence descended over the main road.

I nudged the unconscious giants with my foot, then shrugged at the young man. The corners of his mouth, which had been raised so high moments before, were now trembling.

“Interesting. Very interesting. Don’t you all think so too?”

The Zhuge Clan retainer put a hand to his forehead, while Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin nodded mechanically.

“This is the most fun I’ve had in all my thirty years as a beggar.”

“Captain, I laughed so hard my belly button fell off. I can’t see where it rolled, so I’m still looking for it.”

“Right. In times as bleak as these, how could we simply let the man who gave us such wonderful entertainment leave? So… grab that bastard by the collar and escort him over here.”

“Loyalty, loyalty!”

“I give up. Whatever happens, you’ll deal with it yourself.”

Hyuk Mujin, desperate to avoid even a single blow, threw himself into the task with greater enthusiasm than anyone else. Gung Gibang stepped forward as well, despite his grumbling.

The situation had completely reversed from how it had begun.

Once even their trusted guards were defeated, the men and women of Qingxia Hall began shrieking at the tops of their lungs.

“Y-you bastard! Do you know who I am?”

“You wretched scoundrel! How dare you defy the laws of the Great Nation!”

“If you lay a hand on me, do you think my family will stand by and do nothing?”

I had only meant to grab one person, but these people were apparently set items that came attached in a chain.

I turned to the first one who had shouted.

“Who are you?”

“I am the Young Bureau Head of the Daejuksan Escort Bureau…”

“Oh, Juksan Escort Bureau?”

“So you do know us!”

“I don’t, you sibu-leol[2152] bastard. Get down before I beat you into juk.”[2153]

They might have thrown their weight around in Hubei Province, but if I’d never heard of them, they were nobodies.

I continued quietly.

“Get down now, and I’ll only destroy the palanquin. Refuse, and I’ll destroy your legs along with it. What’ll it be?”

[2152] *Sibu-leol* is a Korean profanity, roughly equivalent to “fuck.”

[2153] *Juk* is Korean rice porridge, continuing Taekyung’s wordplay on “Juksan.”

The Young Bureau Head of the Daejuksan Escort Bureau widened his eyes and answered,

“I’ll get down.”

“You should’ve done that from the start. Why are your eyes so wide?”

“I’m sorry. If I don’t do this, I think I might cry…”

Ah. That was understandable.

After dealing with one of them easily, I turned to the sharp-voiced woman.

“What family did you say you were from?”

“Hmph! No matter how much of a scoundrel you are, surely you’ve heard of the name of the Hyungmun Sword Family!”

“Never heard of it. Stop talking nonsense and get down.”

“…!”

“Next. Where are you from?”

“I-I’m from the Eungseong Merchant Association…”

“Eungseong, Eung-shit, whatever. Get down unless you want me to beat you until you crap yourself.”

“Yes, sir.”

After two or three of them climbed down from their sedan chairs, the rest began touching their feet to the ground one by one without even speaking.

All except one.

“So, who are you?”

Every trace of laughter had vanished from the young man’s face. His eyes gleamed coldly.

“You have crossed a line you should never have crossed.”

“Looks like you’ve crossed your lifeline too. So who are you?”

“Heh. What a ridiculous situation.”

The young man gave a hollow laugh, then shouted in a dignified voice,

“I, Ju Wongong, am a noble scion of the dragon’s blood and a third cousin of His Majesty the Emperor! If you know your crime, kneel even now!”

“Okay, Celestial Dragon.[2154] Get down.”

“…!”

[2154] The privileged World Nobles in *One Piece*, infamous for treating ordinary people as beneath them.

Chapter 454

The young man who had frozen with his eyes wide—or rather, Ju Wongong—asked in a trembling voice,

“W-what did you say?”

Had this bastard’s ears been plugged this whole time? He kept making me repeat myself.

Ignoring the people staring back and forth between Ju Wongong and me with their mouths hanging open, I spoke again.

“Get down.”

“I-I am Ju Wongong!”

“Main character, Ju Wongong, whatever. Get down.”

“You are a subject of the Great Nation! How dare you show such disrespect to a member of His Majesty the Emperor’s own bloodline?”

“I have a friend named Johnson.[2155] If he were here, he’d have violated something else.”

“…!”

“I’ll say it one last time. Get down.”

He had no idea what I meant, but anyone with human instincts could sense danger.

Ju Wongong’s butt twitched instinctively, and he slowly rose to his feet.

Yet even as his eyes darted around in anxiety at this unprecedented situation, he didn’t forget to threaten me until the bitter end. Apparently, he still trusted his imperial pedigree to protect him.

“D-do you think you’ll get away with this?”

“Yeah. I think I will.”

“To insult an imperial relative? This is treason!”

“As long as it’s not hair loss.”

“What kind of bastard says things like that…!”

Although I answered casually, I was not entirely wrong.

The imperial family bore the same Zhu surname as the Son of Heaven and carried the blood of dragons. That alone made them noble.

Even though Murim and the government maintained a relationship of mutual noninterference, disrespecting or threatening an imperial relative was treated as a serious crime.

There was a reason the Zhuge Clan retainer had been whining like a dog desperate to relieve itself.

[2155] Johnson is the name of an American talk-show host Taekyung has encountered; “johnson” is also slang for a penis.

"P-perhaps it would be best if you stopped now."

I frowned at his whisper.

"Why?"

"Pardon?"

"What did I do? I didn't swear at him or threaten to kill him. His side even attacked first. All I did was tell him to get down from the four-person sedan chair."

"…Well, if you put it that way, you're right. But he is still an imperial relative."

"Imperial relatives come in all grades. If he's eight degrees removed, he's not really a blood relative. They just have a few drops of blood in common. If I spat into the Yangtze right now, the river and I would probably be about eight degrees apart too."

"Gasp. Great Hero Jin, please."

"It's fine. I said it quietly, so no one could've heard us anyway."

At that moment, Ju Wongong misread our whispering and shouted triumphantly.

"It seems you have finally grasped the gravity of the situation. But it is already too late! The imperial court will soon dispatch a hundred thousand troops to exterminate the nine branches of your kin,[2156] along with those of every other traitor!"

"Oh. A Buster Call.[2157]"

"What have you been babbling about this whole time, you traitorous bastard?"

"Gasp!"

"Eek!"

When unmistakable fury filled Ju Wongong's eyes, the commoners sucked in their breaths and threw themselves flat on the ground. Some had already begun fleeing in every direction.

They seemed eager to avoid being dragged into someone else's trouble. That meant fewer eyes watching us, so I had no complaints.

They keep threatening people with the nine branches of their kin[2158] whenever they get bored.

Did they not bother with anything less?

As I let out a deep sigh, the Zhuge Clan retainer whispered,

"Don't be too frightened. His talk of a hundred thousand troops is only a bluff."

"…Do you think I'm an idiot? Why would I believe that?"

[2156] Punishing nine branches of a person's kin refers to extending a treason sentence across the offender's family.

[2157] A Buster Call is an order for a devastating naval attack in *One Piece*.

[2158] Punishing nine branches of a person's kin refers to extending a treason sentence across the offender's family.

“Master Ju was exiled for using his imperial authority to embezzle a fortune, so he won’t want to make this matter any bigger. Please apologize and withdraw while you still can.”

“Wait. Exiled?”

“Yes.”

“Him?”

“He is an imperial relative. No matter how distant his branch may be, his blood cannot be ignored. Besides, he is a distant branch with no chance of inheriting the throne, so even when he commits a crime, they allow him to enjoy a certain amount of special treatment.”

“In short, he’s such a fucking nobody that no one around him even bothers with him?”

“…Great Hero Jin, please choose your words more carefully.”

I let the retainer’s complaint go in one ear and out the other, then laughed quietly.

I had wondered why someone who was supposedly an imperial relative was hanging around with a gang of thugs on a main road in Hubei instead of living in the imperial palace. It turned out he was even less important than I had imagined.

Though I had already suspected as much when he started talking about being eight degrees removed.

“First, I shall gouge out those arrogant eyes of yours for failing to recognize this noble self. Then I shall tear you limb from limb, and afterward—”

“Yeah, yeah. I get it. Look at this first, then we can talk about the rest.”

I pulled something from inside my robe and tossed it at Ju Wongong as he delivered his grand speech.

At the same time, the man who had been puffing out his chest flailed both arms and sat down hard.

“A hidden weapon! A hidden weapon! This bastard is trying to assassinate an imperial relative!”

“…You really are something else.”

And then—

The “hidden weapon” landed with a soft clack in front of Ju Wongong’s feet, scattering a brilliant light beneath everyone’s gaze.

“Huh?”

Ju Wongong stared at the object with puzzled eyes, his mouth hanging open.

“Huh? Huh? Huhhhhhh!”

It didn’t take long for his question marks to become exclamation marks, or for his anger to turn to shock.

He looked back and forth between me and Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao’s token, engraved with clouds and a dragon. Then he spoke in a grave voice.

“I shall show you mercy and forgive you.”

“…”

What a load of crap.

“So you were on your way to Dongting Lake?”

“That is correct! No, I mean, yes, that is so!”

Ju Wongong nodded vigorously at my gentle tone.

The decorative showpieces from Qingxia Hall whom he had hired were warning people to keep their mouths shut alongside the government troops, who had arrived late. Meanwhile, Cheongpung, who had somehow succeeded in buying dumplings in bulk, opened his eyes wide at the mention of Dongting Lake.

“Wow! Dongting Lake!”

Ju Wongong had finally learned the identity of this dumpling ghost. His uneasy gaze flicked toward the sword hanging at Cheongpung’s waist.

“W-well, I could invite you along if you wished…”

I muttered,

“You don’t mean that at all.”

“That is a misunderstanding! No, I mean, you misunderstand.”

“Do you misunderstand things this often? Considering you attacked people who were trying to pass by peacefully, it certainly seems that way.”

“That was… I shall apologize once again. I never dreamed that you possessed His Highness Prince Shangshan’s token.”

“Oh, I see. So if I hadn’t had the token, you would’ve brought a hundred thousand troops to exterminate nine branches of my family,[2159] gouged out my eyes, and torn me limb from limb?”

“W-why would you say such a thing? Ha, ha-ha-ha.”

His forced laughter was almost pitiful.

I didn’t know the token would have this much power either.

There was a reason Ju Wongong had become so submissive.

Even animals were judged as purebred or mixed-breed. How much more would the imperial family—the noblest bloodline in the world—care about such distinctions?

Even though the same imperial blood ran in their veins, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao was the Son of Heaven’s only younger full brother and the sole prince he had personally appointed.

[2159] Punishing nine branches of a person’s kin refers to extending a treason sentence across the offender’s family.

After the late Emperor's death, the ruthless man who now sat upon the throne had eliminated countless blood relatives in the struggle for succession. Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao was that ruthless Emperor's one soft spot.

Ju Wongong, on the other hand, came from a collateral branch eight degrees removed.

The direct imperial line possessed legitimacy and authority. Even by counting degrees of kinship, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao was a distant and exalted elder of the household to Ju Wongong.

This is what they call using barbarians to defeat barbarians.

Defeat barbarians with barbarians, and a weak Celestial Dragon[2160] with a strong Celestial Dragon.[2161]

The chairman of my fan club was this formidable. Just thinking about it made my heart swell.

"Well, putting that aside, what are you planning to do at Dongting Lake?"

"W-well, the weather is pleasant, so I thought I might go boating…"

At my incredulous expression, Ju Wongong hurriedly corrected himself.

"I intended to go boating while also inspecting the people's welfare, since I heard the mood in Hubei Province has been rather grim lately."

"…Shouldn't you inspect your own life first? I heard you were exiled for siphoning off a fortune through back channels."

"Ahem! Ahem!"

"And you brought all these people along for a boat ride? At a time like this?"

Everyone in Hubei Province with eyes and ears was trembling with anxiety over the grim rumors that refused to die down, yet this exiled imperial relative was planning a lavish boating excursion on Dongting Lake.

If Mr. Current Situation heard about this and smashed Ju Wongong's skull with a sledgehammer, Ju Wongong would have no right to complain.

That's rich people for you.

I shook my head and rose from my seat.

The matter had been settled without too much fuss, so I intended to leave and forget about it. Ju Wongong seemed to take it differently.

"W-wait a moment. Where are you going?"

"I'm a busy man. I have more important things to do than go boating on Dongting Lake. Why?"

"If I have offended you, I shall apologize once again. And in that spirit…"

Ju Wongong trailed off and gave a meaningful glance.

[2160] The Celestial Dragons in *One Piece* are privileged nobles who claim exceptional status by birth.

[2161] The Celestial Dragons in *One Piece* are privileged nobles who claim exceptional status by birth.

The Qingxia Hall martial artists who had been waiting for his signal carried over one of the ornate sedan chairs positioned throughout the procession.

They hadn't even drawn back its curtains, yet a faint fragrance drifted into my nose.

Don't tell me…

There was an old saying that the thing you dismissed with "surely not" was the thing most likely to get you. This time was no different.

"Show yourself."

The moment Ju Wongong spoke, the sedan chair's door slid open.

A woman carefully stepped down, and an exclamation escaped my lips before I could stop it.

"…Whoa."

People often describe celebrities as pretty or handsome.

But the woman before me possessed something beyond those ordinary standards.

Beautiful.

Yes. That was probably the right word.

She was beautiful enough to draw admiration even from me, despite the fact that I had already guessed Ju Wongong's intentions.

Beautiful enough to make Gung Gibang hurriedly wash his face with spit and Hyuk Mujin stare in a daze. Beautiful enough to make Cheongpung—who had been holding a meat dumpling in one hand and a vegetable dumpling in the other, trying to choose between them—drop them both.

As the quiet shock rippled through the crowd, Ju Wongong's voice reached me.

"She is the singing courtesan I keep at my side. As you can see, her beauty deserves to be called unrivaled beneath the heavens. She is also extraordinarily skilled in music. Anyone who hears her play loses himself completely."

I wasn't so sure she needed the music. She looked capable of stealing a person's soul without playing a single note.

Ju Wongong laughed quietly at the admiration plain on my face, then turned to the woman.

"What are you waiting for? Hurry and greet him."

Her red lips slowly parted.

"This humble girl is called Honglan. It is my greatest pleasure to meet such an honored guest."

"…Oh."

"…Wow."

"…Amazing."

Before the shock of her appearance had even faded, exclamations burst out from every direction.

Her voice was clear and pure, yet alluring.

Honglan. Red Orchid. The name suited her better than anyone.

Of course, it wasn't her real name, and she wasn't an ordinary singing courtesan either.

Like most courtesans, including Wolhwa, Honglan concealed her true name.

And unlike Ju Wongong, who knew absolutely nothing about martial arts, she had received at least some training.

Lower District Sect?

Her slender shoulder twitched at my Sound Transmission, and Honglan gave a slight nod.

The Lower District Sect. I had a feeling that was it.

The Lower District Sect had more disciples than any organization apart from the Beggars' Sect.

Ju Wongong didn't seem aware of it, but like the Lower District Sect's other courtesans, Honglan had learned enough martial arts to protect herself.

"So? What do you think, Great Hero Jin? Give me the opportunity, and this Young Master will treat you properly. Of course, Honglan will sit beside you…"

Let's see you refuse to come along after this.

The words were written plainly across Ju Wongong's smug face.

I gazed at Honglan for a moment, then smiled.

"Forget it. Let's each continue on our way."

"Then we can all go somewhere else together—hm? W-wait. What did you just say?"

"Why are you so flustered? I'm pretty sure I said I had something urgent to do. Is my memory failing me?"

"N-no. But Honglan is here…"

I raised a hand and cut Ju Wongong off.

I had already wasted enough time getting dragged into this nonsense. If I were the kind of man who lost his head over a beautiful woman and followed her wherever she went, I wouldn't have survived this long.

"Don't overdo the partying. You'd be better off going home and keeping your head down. See you."

I was about to turn away when Ju Wongong held something out to me.

"Wait! Then at least this."

"…?"

"I heard that His Highness Prince Shangshan received your autograph, Great Hero Jin. Please give me one as well…"

"…!"

At this rate, my fan café would be reaching Leaf Level 2 soon.[2162]

[2162] Korean online fan cafés use membership ranks; “Leaf Level 2” is one such rank.

Chapter 455

"Cough, cough."

Hunched over like a shrimp, the old man coughed with difficulty.

Whenever he moved, the chill rising from the underground prison's cold stone floor seeped into his bones.

Yet no illness could take root in his body.

The several jiazi[2163] of internal energy accumulated in his dantian over the long years no longer obeyed his control, but they were more than enough to protect his aged body.

And that only enraged him further.

Damn it…!

The already ugly old man's features twisted into the face of a fiend.

Once, he had crossed the continent and left countless storms of blood in his wake. Now he was being treated like livestock that could be slaughtered at any moment.

"Then kill me! If you're going to subject me to such humiliation, just kill me already!"

As the old man writhed and let out a tearing scream, the chains binding his body tightly grated against one another.

But like the internal energy sealed within his dantian, the dozen or so iron balls attached to those chains did not budge an inch.

"You bastaaaardsss!"

Though his martial arts had been sealed and he could no longer display his former might, his innate viciousness remained unchanged.

The old man glared through the thick iron bars with bloodshot eyes. Faces that must have been laughing at him somewhere flashed before his eyes like hallucinations.

"You bastards…!"

A grudge etched into his bones and soul.

They had killed his two brothers, born on the same day and hour as him, with whom he had spent his entire life. The old man himself had been captured and subjected to every humiliation imaginable.

They had even crushed his testicles as though castrating livestock. Calling them mortal enemies did not begin to describe it.

"Fine. Then I'll survive, no matter what it takes."

Flames poured from the old man's eyes.

"I will escape this place and rip you bastards apart alive!"

[2163] A **jiazi** is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

His shout, thick with killing intent, echoed through the underground prison.

That was when a voice spoke.

“I heard your escape pledge. Quite moving.”

“…!”

When did he—?

The old man blinked. One of the faces that had flashed before his eyes moments ago was now staring at him from beyond the bars.

The smile on the young man’s lips sent a chill through his chest.

“Y-you…”

“How’s the busted part? Must hurt every time you take a piss.”

The old man almost nodded without realizing it.

But this young man’s name stood alongside the others at the very top of his kill list. He was someone the old man had to kill, whatever the cost.

The old man glared at him through the bars, eyes gleaming.

“If you’re curious, lift the seal on my martial arts right now. I’ll show you myself.”

“I’m not particularly curious about that…”

The smile on the young man’s lips—Jin Taekyung’s lips—vanished as if wiped away.

“You’ll have to tell me everything else you know, Third Fiend.”

In the modern world, torturing prisoners was classified as an illegal act. If such a fact became known, even a Great Nation would be condemned by the international community.

But this was Murim. The authority of the law was hazy, and the line between man and beast even hazier.

And as far as I was concerned, the Third Fiend was closer to a beast wearing human skin.

There’s no reason to hesitate.

He had harmed countless people over the course of many years.

He was a fiend who had slaughtered hundreds—thousands—of people merely to satisfy his bloodlust.

There was no room for flimsy morality on the bloody road he had walked, or in this damp, dark underground prison.

I stared coldly at the Third Fiend.

“Guhk… Hnggg…”

His body hung limp, bound to an iron chair.

Bloodstained saliva dripped from his open mouth, and his limbs, torn and broken all over, spasmed with pain.

"How is he?"

At my question, the old man examining him scratched his head with a bloodstained iron skewer.

"He has already reached his limit. At this point, we must assume he has confessed everything he knows."

If torture skill were divided into realm stages, I was barely First Rate. The old man before me was a Supreme Peak master.

He had handled prisoners with such efficient cruelty during the Great Faction War that Zhuge Gonghu, the Fan-Wisdom King, had taken note of his methods and invited him to join the Zhuge Clan after the war.

"If we keep going…"

"He will die. Without fail. And in this old man's opinion, beating him any further will yield nothing more."

The old man's voice rang with certainty.

The appearance of the Third Fiend, who had become half a corpse, and his aura, which seemed ready to go out at any moment, lent even greater weight to those words.

But this wasn't enough. I stared at the Third Fiend as he trembled, nearly senseless.

Is this really everything?

It wasn't as though he had known nothing.

For the first few shichen,[2164] he had held out through sheer spite. But as the torture neared its final stages, he had grown talkative enough to fill five bamboo slips with densely packed writing.

Yet most of it was useless or concerned events from the past, and the information I needed most had never come out.

The series of incidents happening in Hubei Province right now.

The Sea Serpent Society had fallen, and Donghu Stronghold had been massacred.

The casualties had already far exceeded a thousand, including innocent commoners who did not know even a single martial move or half a stance.

As far as I knew, only one group possessed both the power and the sheer brutality to commit such madness.

Dark Heaven.

The problem was that I could not get hold of their trail.

Where and how had they attacked the Sea Serpent Society and Donghu Stronghold? Where had they hidden the Moving Formation?

[2164] A **shichen** is a traditional time unit of roughly two hours.

And finally, where were the perpetrators now, and what were they doing?

“This won’t do.”

Muttering under my breath, I grabbed the unconscious Third Fiend by the wrist. The old man, who had been standing nearby with a bored expression, hurriedly tried to stop me.

“Great Hero, if you do that—!”

“It’s fine. I’m not trying to kill him.”

I sent internal energy through the Third Fiend’s wrist. As the warmth of Scorching Yang Qi flowed along his acupoints, color returned to his pale cheeks and his eyelids lifted.

My face appeared in his unfocused, trembling gray eyes.

“Y-you…”

“Wake up. It’s still too early.”

“J-just kill me.”

“Tell me everything you know, and you’ll get your wish. But if you insist on pretending to be a loyal servant…”

I poured more force into the faint stream of internal energy. The Third Fiend’s eyes flew open with a sharp gasp.

His body was already ruined inside and out. It could not endure the heat of Scorching Yang Qi.

“Ghk… Gack.”

His painful, gasping breaths carried the smell of meat being cooked. But I continued staring at the Third Fiend without wavering.

“That’s not the answer I want.”

“This old man—I have already told you everything.”

“Not that either.”

“Ghk. P-please…”

“If you can still hold out like this, you’re nowhere near death yet. Just like there’s still information I haven’t heard.”

“What else could you possibly want me to say…?”

“I’ve told you several times already. Everything about Dark Heaven. What’s happening in Hubei Province, and the Dongting Fisherman.”

“I told you, I don’t know—kuweeegh!”

With every exchange, the Scorching Yang Qi grew stronger.

The Third Fiend trembled violently, eyes rolling back until only the whites showed. A scream tore from his lips.

“Kill me! Hurry up and kill me! Even as a vengeful ghost, I’ll chew through your flesh and bones…!”

Damn it. That was as far as I could go.

I abruptly withdrew the internal energy I had been forcing into him. The Third Fiend immediately went limp, like a puppet with its strings cut.

Changing the flow, I gently stabilized his body from within. The old man, already standing by, quickly took his pulse and checked his condition.

“He’s a hard one to kill. Stopped right on the threshold of the afterlife.”

I knew. I had controlled my strength as carefully as possible to keep him alive.

He can’t die here.

The Third Fiend was one of the great fiends of the previous generation and a Supreme Peak master of Dark Heaven.

If we kept him alive and escorted him to Henan, there might be a way to learn even more information.

Of course, I couldn’t dismiss the possibility that those bamboo slips contained everything he knew.

No. That was probably the likeliest possibility.

If he still didn’t talk after all this… maybe he really has told us everything.

The mental strength and endurance of a Supreme Peak master defied imagination.

Yet the Third Fiend had begged me—someone no different from his mortal enemy—to stop. He had screamed for me to kill him instead.

And still, he had never changed his story.

I—I and my brothers only followed orders under the Demon Lord! I don’t know anything about Dark Heaven’s headquarters or what happened elsewhere, I tell you!

Remembering the cries he had repeated throughout the torture, I called out a name.

“Gung Gibang. Any news?”

Gung Gibang, leaning against the iron bars, shook his head.

“Nothing. Our Hubei branch still hasn’t found them.”

“Three Supreme Peak masters—or hundreds of people and ships—must have been mobilized. There’s no way they could’ve avoided attention. If we focus on outsiders, we might have a chance…”

“We already are, but it isn’t easy. Hundreds of large ships travel the Hubei stretch of the Yangtze every day, and the people moving by land are too numerous to count. And if this happened a good ten days ago… there’s a strong chance they’ve already left Hubei by one means or another.”

“Damn it.”

Unlike Shanxi Province, which was treated as a borderland, Hubei Province was part of the region known as the Central Plains, and its industries were well developed.

With merchants and travelers constantly pouring in and out of such a vast territory, even the Beggars’ Sect was bound to struggle.

Gung Gibang watched my expression, then spoke cautiously.

"Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin went to the Lower District Sect, so all we can do is hope they found something. Their findings probably won't be much different from those of our Hubei branch, but… we have to hold on to hope."

Gung Gibang was right.

Half a shichen later, Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin returned to the Zhuge Clan carrying a large bundle of bamboo slips.

A single man's sobriquet was written on the cord binding them together.

Dongting Fisherman.

"This…"

Hyuk Mujin swallowed hard before continuing.

"It seems the Lower District Sect had some sort of dispute with the Dongting Fisherman. They said they've been keeping a close watch on him for several years under the Sect Leader's orders… You should probably read it yourself."

I quickly skimmed the contents of the bamboo slips.

Their records on the Dongting Fisherman went back no fewer than three years, and the bundle in my hands contained only a portion of them.

The records from one month ago through today revealed one fact.

The Dongting Fisherman is still in Hubei Province.

Which meant…

Clatter!

I shoved the bamboo slips into my robe and immediately went in search of one man.

Zhuge Gyun, the Divine Marvel Dragon and Lesser Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, had been issuing orders in place of the Family Head, Zhuge Feng. His eyes widened at my noisy arrival.

"What brings you here in such haste? My ancestor Zhuge Wuhou said that a junzi[2165] should always conduct himself properly and remain tranquil…"

"Shut up. Are the people ready?"

"The people my fath—no, the Family Head mentioned are already prepared to leave. Do you intend to depart immediately?"

"Yeah. But I think I need to stop somewhere else first."

"Pardon? Where…?"

"Dongting Lake."

[2165] A **junzi** is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright gentleman.

Chapter 456

“Dongting Lake, out of nowhere? What do you mean?”

Zhuge Gyun’s confusion lasted only a moment. Though he occasionally behaved like an eccentric, his mind was as sharp as one would expect from a scion of the Zhuge Clan.

His epithet, the Divine Marvel Dragon, had not been bestowed on him merely because of his deep understanding of mechanisms and formations.

“Are you trying to find the Dongting Fisherman?”

Several shichen[2166] earlier, when I first arrived at the Zhuge Clan, Zhuge Gyun had heard the full circumstances of the case from me. He also knew that the Dongting Fisherman had been identified as one of the culprits.

“Yeah.”

“Given how suddenly you’re acting… I assume your information came from the Beggars’ Sect and the Lower District Sect.”

“More precisely, the Lower District Sect. They’ve been watching the Dongting Fisherman for three years.”

“Not watching. Monitoring. Our family had also noticed that something had happened between the Dongting Fisherman and the Lower District Sect Leader.”

“Either way, it works in our favor. Read this.”

Zhuge Gyun took the bamboo slip from me, and his eyes moved rapidly across it.

He read every last word in mere moments, then rubbed his temple and muttered, “The Dongting Fisherman is still in Hubei Province?”

“That’s what the Lower District Sect’s intelligence says.”

“This is insufficient. According to what is written on this bamboo slip, the Lower District Sect has not determined the Dongting Fisherman’s exact whereabouts. They merely failed to detect him leaving Hubei Province.”

“I’ve considered that too. But what if the information is accurate?”

“If it is…”

The Dongting Fisherman, whom everyone believed to be dead, was alive and well somewhere in Hubei Province?

That could mean only one thing.

“If the Dongting Fisherman really is a Dark Heaven underling and one of the culprits who massacred Donghu Stronghold, then it would certainly be possible. No—in fact, it would make it even more certain that he is a culprit.”

Zhuge Gyun nodded gravely.

[2166] A **shichen** is a traditional time unit of roughly two hours.

“Indeed. If he were not affiliated with Dark Heaven, he would already have informed the world of the tragedy at Donghu Stronghold and requested assistance from our family and Wudang.”

After the Sea Serpent Society, three strongholds of the Yangtze River Channel League—including Donghu Stronghold—had been annihilated.

If we had not arrived when we did—and if it had not been for Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song and the swift ship under his command—the tragedy at Donghu Stronghold beyond Tianling Falls would have remained unknown for much longer.

“But one question remains. This is not something that can be concealed forever. It might take time, but the truth was bound to come out. If Dark Heaven had truly intended to cover it up, they would have handled everything more quietly, without drawing public attention. They could have laid the blame for the Sea Serpent Society’s destruction on the Yangtze River Channel League.”

He was right. The Zhuge Clan and Wudang had been unable to cross Tianling Falls only because they lacked vessels sturdy enough for the journey and skilled boatmen to pilot them.

Even if they could not rely on Mu Song and the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold, they would eventually have found suitable men elsewhere.

Zhuge Gyun stared pensively at the bamboo slip before raising his head to look at me.

“Then why go this far?”

I took a drink from the cup on the table to wet my throat.

“Under ordinary circumstances, they would’ve done it to buy time.”

“Exactly. Dark Heaven would have needed time to escape. But the fact that the Dongting Fisherman is still in Hubei Province is strange.”

“Yeah. It’s strange. So strange that the pieces don’t fit.”

When I answered without hesitation, Zhuge Gyun’s eyebrows rose slightly.

“You have another theory.”

“I said under ordinary circumstances.”

“Then…”

“Dark Heaven isn’t made up of ordinary people. You experienced them in Henan, so you should know that.”

“…!”

“They throw a pebble first to draw everyone’s attention, then get a boulder ready. This won’t end with the Sea Serpent Society and three strongholds. They’re definitely after something bigger.”

Dark Heaven’s power and audacity defied common sense.

Two Supreme Peak masters of the previous generation, both counted among the Ten Kings, had already died. Thousands more had fallen in sprays of blood.

And the two blood-soaked disasters Dark Heaven had caused shared one clear objective.

“Divine artifacts…”

At Zhuge Gyun’s low murmur, I quietly nodded.

In Henan, Dark Heaven had stolen Shaolin Temple’s divine artifact, the Green Jade Buddha Staff. When they attacked Sichuan, they had attempted to seize the Myriad-Poison Ring.

Fortunately, their operation in Sichuan had failed, but what they were after was obvious.

Divine artifacts—or the destruction of the prestigious great sects known as the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

It was hard to believe that people like that had gone to such lengths merely to wipe out a sect like the Sea Serpent Society, whose members were just trying to make a living, and three strongholds.

It might have made sense if they had targeted the headquarters of the Yangtze River Channel League, where the Seafaring King was based.

Zhuge Gyun’s expression stiffened.

“Then the culprits, including the Dongting Fisherman, have ample reason to remain in Hubei Province.”

“It’s still only speculation, but for now, we have to assume they drew everyone’s attention elsewhere in preparation for something bigger. The delay was just a smokescreen meant to convince us they’d already left Hubei Province.”

“The darkest place is directly beneath the lamp… But could they not have already vanished through that bizarre Moving Formation?”

“You might as well tell me Cheongpung walked past a dumpling shop.”

“Oh. Now that you put it that way, I understand completely.”

I stared hard into empty space.

“What happened to the Sea Serpent Society and Donghu Stronghold was the pebble. The boulder comes next.”

The pond called Hubei Province was vast. Even if a pebble fell into it, the ripples would not travel far before subsiding.

If a boulder fell, however, it would send water surging into the air—and the fish in the pond would not escape unharmed.

We had to stop the boulder from falling before the pond was dyed with blood.

“I will inform the local authorities and Wudang in preparation for the worst. I will also strengthen our defenses inside and out.”

“Watch the government troops carefully. You’ve heard what happened in Sichuan, haven’t you?”

The forces of Dark Heaven, led by the Western Heaven Demon Lord, had disguised themselves as government troops and swept through the Tang Clan, Emei, and Qingcheng.

It was already common knowledge. There was no way Zhuge Gyun, the Lesser Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, could be unaware of it.

“I am already taking precautions, though I doubt they will use the same method twice.”

“Inform Donghu Stronghold too. The swift ship from Water Dragon Stronghold should be waiting at the Zaoyang ferry, so entrust the letter to our family retainers.”

A messenger pigeon would have been faster and more convenient, but it could be intercepted along the way. Besides, the Zhuge Clan had no messenger pigeons trained to fly to and from Donghu Stronghold.

The other two strongholds that had been able to communicate with Donghu Stronghold had already been wiped out, too.

The gruesome sea of corpses and blood flashed before my eyes, and my fist tightened before I realized it.

Shanxi. Henan. Sichuan. Then the monster wave in Sichuan Province in the modern world. Traveling between two worlds, I had already witnessed far too many deaths.

Scrape.

As I rose from my seat, Zhuge Gyun asked, “Are you leaving right now?”

“The sooner, the better. I don’t know where the Dongting Fisherman is, but we need to start at Dongting Lake and look for traces.”

“That will not be easy. The Dongting Fisherman spent his entire life around Dongting Lake, so he likely knows several secret refuges unknown to the rest of the world.”

I clenched my fist.

“Hey. Are you Dark Heaven?”

“Pardon?”

“I asked if you’re Dark Heaven.”

“Ah, no.”

“Then stop saying ominous things and cheer me on, you bastard.”

Zhuge Gyun glanced at my fist and answered at once.

“Yes, sir. For now, I will mobilize all of our family’s intelligence resources and cooperate with the Beggars’ Sect and the Lower District Sect to search every region outside Dongting Lake.”

“Do a good job. I’m leaving.”

I was about to turn away when I realized I had forgotten one important question.

“Wait. Does the Zhuge Clan have any divine artifacts?”

“Of course. There is the Four-Wheeled Cart our ancestor Zhuge Wuhou rode during his lifetime, the Twenty-Four Chapters on the Art of War, in which he compiled his insights, and the White Feather Fan.”

“…That’s quite a collection.”

I had no idea how impressive a wheelchair, a book, and a fan could be as divine artifacts, but it was worth checking just in case.

I turned to Zhuge Gyun.

“Let me see them for a minute. There’s something I need to confirm.”

“We had them, but we don’t anymore.”

“…?”

“The Twenty-Four Chapters on the Art of War were lost during a war, and the White Feather Fan crumbled with age. As for the Four-Wheeled Cart, I heard that one of our former Family Heads rode it and broke it around two hundred years ago. I cannot remember his name.”

“…”

What the fuck.

Was this some grand strategy to destroy their own treasures before Dark Heaven could steal them?

Judging by the artifacts themselves, they seemed to have been significant only because Zhuge Wuhou had left them behind. Still, the whole thing was absurd.

“The Four-Wheeled Cart is still here in its broken state. Would you like me to show it to you?”

“No. Forget it.”

I answered firmly and left the pavilion. Outside, beneath the night sky that had once again grown dark, three people stood waiting with all their preparations complete.

Or was it four?

“That bastard’s still breathing, right?”

“Yes, Benefactor.”

Just as I had in Sichuan, Cheongpung carried a wooden pack frame on his back. The Third Fiend lay atop it, every acupoint sealed and his body bound in chains.

“He is very weak, but he should be fine if I use my internal energy from time to time to bolster his vitality.”

“That’s enough.”

There was a simple reason for bringing the Third Fiend along. I wanted to find out whether there were any codes or markings that only members of Dark Heaven could recognize.

That was the sole value of keeping him alive.

“Let’s go to Dongting Lake.”

We left the Zhuge Clan and raced like comets along the straight highway.

The wind rushing over my body seemed tinged with the smell of blood.

Whoooosh!

We raced without conserving our strength.

Hyuk Mujin had less internal energy and an inferior movement technique compared to me, Cheongpung, and Gung Gibang, so he kept falling behind. But it was not much of a problem.

“Get on my back.”

Drenched in sweat from head to toe, Hyuk Mujin shook his head with effort.

“Huff, huff. No, sir. I can keep running!”

“I know you’re struggling. Get on.”

“Huff, I am truly fine. I am the Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan! I cannot cause trouble for my family or Captain—”

“Did a guy like you run around trying to pick up silver nyang[2167]?”

“…”

“Get on if you don’t want to die. Otherwise, I’m leaving you behind.”

“Yes, sir.”

Hyuk Mujin was a fairly large man, but I possessed an extraordinary Strength stat. Carrying one person while running was no great burden.

Why do I suddenly feel like Red Hare?[2168]

I don’t know how long we ran with that strange feeling.

The sky had been only slightly dim when we left the Zhuge Clan, but now it was completely dark. Even the travelers on the highway had disappeared.

After more than two shichen had passed, Gung Gibang, who had been exerting his movement technique at full strength, opened his mouth.

His words, reeking of filth and sickly sweetness, pierced my ears.

“Wuhan.”

Wuhan was the capital of Hubei Province, a city a stone’s throw from Dongting Lake.

But perhaps because of the recent string of ominous incidents, the streets that should have bustled all night were silent. Not even a rat showed its face.

Of course. No ordinary person wants to wander around at night and die like a dog for no reason.

[2167] A **silver nyang** is a historical unit of silver currency.

[2168] **Red Hare** is a famously swift horse associated with the Three Kingdoms era.

I was thinking that as we crossed Wuhan’s maze of streets when it happened.
“Dongting Lake! A ship has sunk in Dongting Lake!”
“…!”
A scream rang out in the distance, shattering the deep, dark silence.

Chapter 457

“Dongting Lake! A ship has sunk in Dongting Lake!”

“P-please, help us! People have fallen into the water!”

Clang, clang—!

Screams rang out in the distance, and the sharp peal of warning bells echoed through the darkness.

But another sound had reached my ears a moment earlier.

Ding.

This is…

A familiar notification.

A chill of foreboding ran down my spine. I stared at the translucent System window floating before my eyes.

SYSTEM

An unexpected Quest, The Tragedy of Dongting Lake, has been generated!

You cannot refuse the Quest!

Quest

The Tragedy of Dongting Lake

Dongting Lake is one of the most celebrated scenic destinations under heaven.

Poets and men of letters climb Yiyang Tower to enjoy its beautiful vistas and compose verses about nature, while those blessed with power and wealth launch large, splendid pleasure boats and revel for days and nights.

But today, this clear, blue-green lake is filled with shattered wreckage and corpses.

Unless someone steps forward, those still alive will meet the same fate!

Grade: Peak

Restriction: Jin Taekyung

Mission: Rescue People (Incomplete)

Reward: ???

Failure: The deaths of the people

A considerable amount of time has already passed. You must rescue the people before it is too late!

As I finished reading the final line of the Quest window, a small holographic window appeared in the air.

SYSTEM

Time Limit: 45 minutes 36 seconds

Damn it. Less than an hour.

If we waste even a moment… everyone will die.

There wasn't even time to wonder how such a catastrophe had happened. Someone's life might depend on every minute—maybe even every second.

I drew as much internal energy as possible from my dantian and opened my mouth.

"From this moment on, run to Dongting Lake as if your lives depend on it. We save the people first."

Whoosh!

No one answered. Their faces simply hardened as they accelerated again.

Using the distant cries and warning bells as our compass, we ran and ran.

By the time the first digit of the time limit changed from four to two, we could finally see it.

Fwoom, roar!

Dozens of vessels, large and small, burned across the broad waters, engulfed in flames as countless shouts rang out from every direction.

"Bring boats! Even a ferryboat will do, so hurry!"

"We don't have enough boatmen!"

"More! Bring more people! Things have come to this, so where are the military vessels? What are they doing?"

"Ahhh! Ahhh!"

With every step, the scene came into sharper focus.

More than a hundred people raced frantically along the shore of Dongting Lake, while several small ferryboats moved slowly across the water.

That won't be enough.

They were doing everything they could, but their efforts fell woefully short of what was needed to rescue so many people.

Even I, with martial arts that more than qualified me as a superhuman, felt my breath catch at the sight.

How are we supposed to save them?

I had heard plenty about the vastness of Dongting Lake, but seeing it for myself, I realized it was far larger than I had imagined.

There was no way the vessels would be packed close together on such a vast lake. Judging from the distances between them, every ship must have been out enjoying

itself at least several hundred zhang[2169] from the others.

And this was only what I could see immediately. How many more boats and people were submerged beyond my sight?

Damn it.

I bit down hard on my lip and accelerated.

The murmurs grew louder as people spotted us racing toward them like the wind.

A military officer who appeared to belong to the local authorities cried out urgently.

“A-are you martial artists? Please, help—”

“No time for explanations. We’re borrowing some boats.”

“Pardon?”

Leaving the dumbfounded officer behind, I thundered an order.

“Gung Gibang, Hyuk Mujin! Smash the ferryboats!”

Whoosh!

There was no hesitation or doubt in either man’s movements.

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin shot past me with forceful shouts, unleashing palm force and sword strikes.

Slash, boom!

The two ferries being hurriedly moved by the people were transformed into hundreds of pieces of wood in an instant.

The military officer, momentarily stunned by what had happened before he could even say anything, screamed,

“What in the world are you doing!”

Shocked cries erupted from every direction.

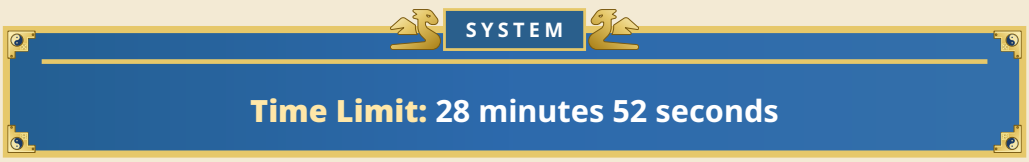
“T-the ferryboats…!”

“Those bastards are the villains who caused this disaster! They must be trying to keep us from rescuing the people!”

Shock and anger spread rapidly. All manner of curses poured in from every side, along with gazes brimming with killing intent.

But I didn’t care.

No—it would be more accurate to say I had no time to care.



Barely thirty minutes remained.

Explaining myself now would only cost more lives.

[2169] A **zhang** is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.3 meters (10.8 ft).

Fortunately, there were three martial artists here who could understand my intentions and act on them.

“Cheongpung, Gung Gibang!”

“Got it!”

“Yes, Benefactor!”

Realizing what I meant, Gung Gibang and Cheongpung scooped up the ferryboat fragments and hurled them with all their strength toward the dark waters of Dongting Lake.

Whoosh, splash!

Dozens of wooden fragments sliced through the darkness and scattered across the lake.

“W-what!”

“Could this be…?”

A few people finally realized what we were doing, their eyes widening. But there still weren’t enough fragments.

Some might even sink before our feet reached them.

In that case…

We’ll have to make the path as we go.

The instant I reached that decision, I stamped down hard.

Boom!

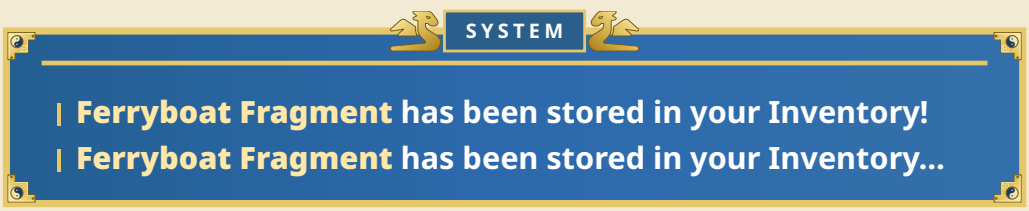
The sand and dust piled along the shore surged into the air all at once, making the unprepared people cough.

Taking advantage of the moment when everyone’s vision was obscured, I reached out.

As my hand met damp, solid wood, I spoke the command only I could use.

Store in Inventory.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Notifications rang in my ears as the wooden fragments dissolved into thin air.

I left behind only enough fragments to avoid arousing suspicion, then shouted forcefully,

“Cheongpung and Gung Gibang, come with me! Hyuk Mujin, stay here and gather boats and people!”

“Y-yes, sir!”

Hyuk Mujin had been gasping for breath for some time now, and he barely managed to squeeze out the words. By then, Cheongpung, Gung Gibang, and I were already shooting toward the dark waters of Dongting Lake.

Whoosh!

Heat surged from my lower abdomen and flowed down into my legs.

Formidable internal energy flooded a body whose muscles and elasticity were so perfect they could be mistaken for a Heavenly Martial Physique.

Now!

Boom!

A massive shock wave burst from my toes, pressed down against the ground, and shoved back the rippling water. Sand and gravel scattered as dust, while a cool wind swept across my entire body.

If I reached out, I felt as though I could pluck the stars scattered across the night sky from the heavens.

But only for a moment.

Every leap was followed by a fall.

Whoooosh!

The black water, surging violently, rushed toward us.

My eyes, as keen as a wild animal's, easily picked out a half-submerged piece of wood.

Tap. Thump!

My landing was light, but the second leap that followed was heavy.

Cheongpung, Gung Gibang, and I launched ourselves forward again.

Using the scattered ferryboat fragments as stepping stones, we leaped once, twice, three times…

Only after repeating the process several times did the vessel that had seemed so far away draw close enough to make out clearly.

But as the distance shrank, the foreboding in my heart grew.

I can't feel any life force.

There were no survivors' screams, no movement—nothing that should have been there if anyone was still alive.

And it did not take long for the foreboding I felt to become reality.

Tap.

On the vessel, most of whose hull was already submerged, Gung Gibang and Cheongpung landed on the bow and muttered like men groaning in pain.

"This is…"

"…Benefactor."

Their voices sounded faint, as if they were coming from hundreds of zhang[2170] away.

In that suffocating silence, I stared blankly around me.

Everywhere I looked, countless corpses floated among the wreckage of shattered ships.

They were dead.

All of them.

A potbellied man who appeared to be a merchant, dressed in splendid silk. A gaunt, shabby-looking boatman. Musicians and courtesans who seemed to have been hired to liven up the festivities.

There were hundreds within sight alone.

No lively music drifted across the black water. No laughter.

All that remained was destruction and death—and the fear plainly etched into the faces of the dead.

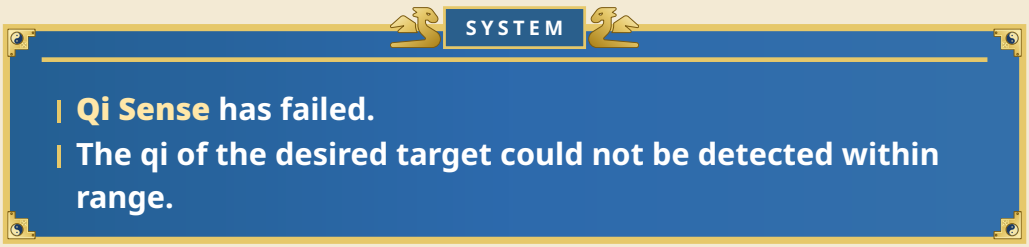
How could this have happened?

For a moment, my mind went completely blank.

As if possessed, I raced across the water from fragment to fragment, using Qi Sense without restraint in search of even a single survivor.

But…

Beep.



The System was more merciless than ever.

The translucent holographic window and grating failure notification told me that there was not a single survivor nearby.

“What in the world…”

I muttered in despair—and then a thought flashed through my mind like lightning.

Wait. The System?

I hurriedly raised my head and stared into the air.

The translucent holographic window was still there.

[2170] A **zhang** is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.3 meters (10.8 ft).

SYSTEM

Time Limit: 9 minutes 43 seconds

"…!"

It felt as if someone had struck me hard in the back of the head.

If there truly were no survivors, the Quest should have been canceled or a failure notification should have appeared. The System was faster and more direct than anything.

But the Quest was still in progress, and the System window displaying the time limit hadn't disappeared.

That could only mean one thing.

As I stood there, frozen stiff, Gung Gibang spoke to me in a cautious voice.

"Unfortunately, it seems pointless to keep searching for survivors…"

"There are survivors."

"What?"

"We just can't see them. There are survivors somewhere much farther away. I'm sure of it."

Gung Gibang had been about to say something, but his expression hardened when he saw the certainty on my face.

Cheongpung spoke in a voice more serious than usual.

"If what you say is true, Benefactor…"

"Then we find them and save them. No matter what it takes."

Gung Gibang stared at me for a moment, then nodded.

"We'll have to split up. If we tear apart the sunken boats around here and use the pieces, we might be able to keep going for another half a shichen.[2171]"

"You have fifteen minutes. Search as far as you can before then. If you don't find any survivors, come back."

The time limit showed how much time the survivors had left. Searching beyond that would be meaningless.

My unusually firm tone puzzled them, but they soon accepted the order without another word.

"We'll do that."

"Fifteen minutes. I'll remember, Benefactor."

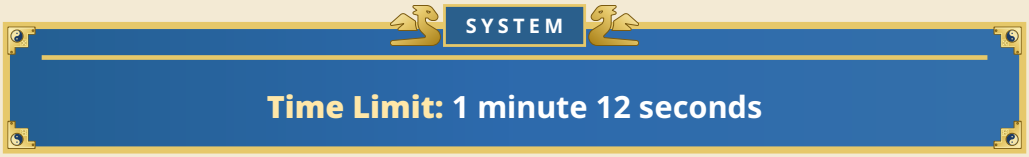
"Then we split up and each take a different direction. See you soon."

Thump, whoosh!

With that, I kicked off the bow and leaped.

[2171] A **shichen** is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Watching the time limit dwindle by the second, I pushed my internal energy and senses to their limits and raced on and on across Dongting Lake, vast as the open sea.



Am I too late?

And just as I was about to give up on everything—

“P-please, save me…”

A tiny, faint voice reached my ears.

Chapter 458

P-please, save me…

Like a dying ember, the voice was tiny and faint.

But that alone was enough. My heart, weighed down by the helplessness of having failed to save anyone, began pounding fiercely, and strength surged through my limp body.

I launched myself toward the voice.

Inventory: Open. Summon!

Thud!

One of the few remaining fragments of the ferryboat skimmed across the moon's reflection on the water.

I leaped through the air like a bird, drew up the last of my internal energy, and focused it in my eyes.

My drastically enhanced vision took in the scene below with perfect clarity.

That's…

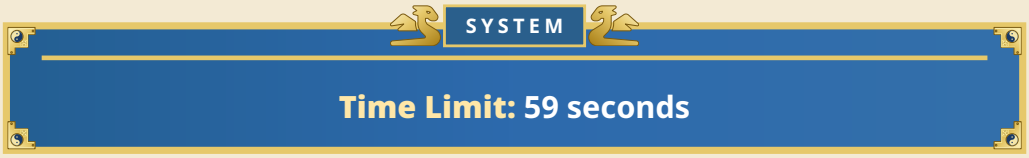
Wreckage and corpses.

Though the vessel had been smashed apart beyond recognition, there was no doubt it had once been the largest and most splendid ship I had seen on Dongting Lake.

There's a survivor somewhere among them.

The problem was that there were far too many corpses and pieces of wreckage in sight.

But there was no time to hesitate.



Fifty-nine seconds. The survivor's life depended on this brief span of less than a minute.

I closed my eyes and steadied my breathing. Then I drew up every last bit of my internal energy, which was already nearly depleted.

Fwooooooosh!

Qi Sense.

The Scorching Yang Qi extending from my entire body raced across the rippling water.

It swept through more than a hundred corpses whose souls had already departed and the countless pieces of wreckage, searching every inch.

And finally—

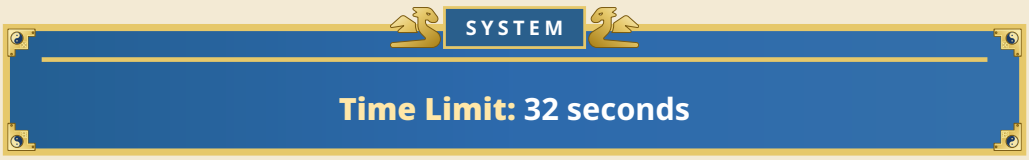
"…!"

I saw it.

No—I felt it.

Dozens of zhang away,[2172] a faint presence was sinking farther beneath the surface with every passing moment.

I opened my eyes halfway.



The Scorching Yang Qi circulating through my body rushed toward my lower half.

When I stepped on empty air with the tips of my toes, the compressed air exploded outward, and a cold wind swept across my entire body.

Boom! Fwooooooosh!

I shot forward like a meteor. The wind split apart, and space vanished.

The scenery flashed past on either side, but my gaze remained fixed on a single point.

The rough, surging black water.

There was a survivor in there.

Damn it. I can't even swim.

The thought had barely crossed my mind when the waters of Dongting Lake slammed into my entire body.

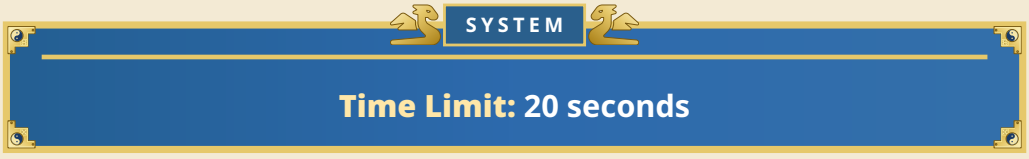
Splash! Gurgle!

The impact knocked the breath out of me.

If I had not learned martial arts, my bones would have broken and my internal organs would have been badly jarred.

I sank beneath the surface, trailing a cloud of bubbles.

A school of fish scattered in alarm at the sudden arrival of an unwelcome visitor, revealing two figures slowly sinking into the depths.



More. More. More…

I summoned every last ounce of strength and pushed forward. Grabbing the wrists of the two unconscious, limp figures, I surged upward with all my might.

[2172] A **zhang** is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.3 meters or 10.9 ft.

Ten seconds. Nine, eight…

The faint moonlight reflected on the surface drew closer.

My arms and legs felt as heavy as if iron balls had been tied to them, while the two people in my hands weighed like thousand-catty boulders.[2173]

And then—

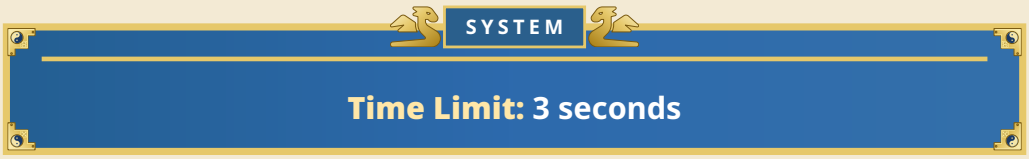
Splash!

“Puaaah!”

I expelled the breath I had been holding.

Air cold enough to sting flowed deep into my lungs.

But pulling the survivors out of the water did not mean everything was over.



In that moment, I instinctively realized what I had to do.

Save them.

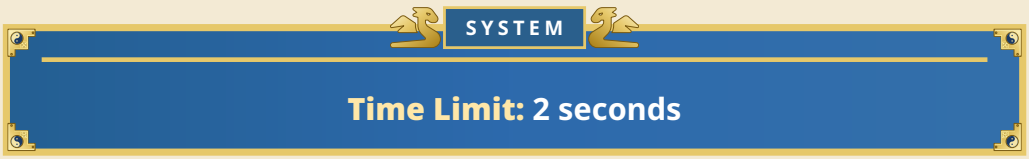
That single thought moved my body, which had briefly gone still.

I thrust both palms, infused with what little internal energy I had left, toward the two people.

Boom!

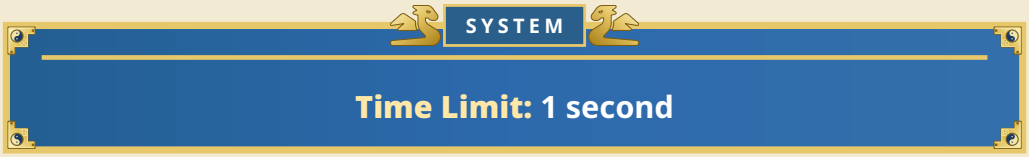
Their bodies jerked, and water splashed.

But the survivors showed no response. Instead, the number on the System window floating in the air changed.



One more time…

Boom!



Everything slowed down.

That paltry digit, 1, seemed larger and heavier than ever, crushing me beneath its weight.

I stared blankly at the System window, eyes wide, when—

[2173] A **catty** is a traditional unit of weight. Here, a thousand catties is approximately 500 kg or 1,100 lb.

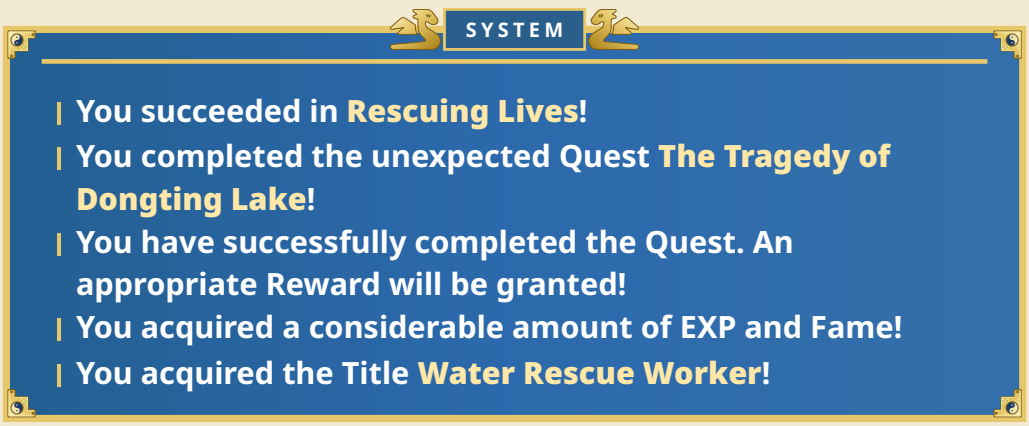
"Puh."

"Cough, cough."

The survivors finally began breathing again. At the same moment, the System window froze just as it was about to change to its final number.

Then a bell rang out like a celebratory salute.

Ding.



As the notifications rang in my ears, I muttered,

"Fuuuck."

Joy and relief at having finally succeeded were secondary. Worn down by the forced march that had begun at the Zhuge Clan, my body felt unbearably heavy.

Maybe it was because the tension I'd barely managed to hold suddenly let go.

...Damn it. It'll take forever to get back to land.

At this rate, would I end up needing to be rescued too?

I was floating there with the two survivors, buoyed by the water, when—

Whoooooosh!

Something sliced through the water in the distance as fast as a jet ski and stopped right in front of me.

A pure-white body and scales, along with two horns.

"A water snake...? No, a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake?"

Hiss. Hiss. Hiss-hiss!

No, don't go!

I hurriedly shouted at the creature as it flicked its tongue and turned away.

"Hey! Hey! Water snake! Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake!"

Hiss!

"You little bastard, did you just spit at me—wait."

Was this its way of showing that it was sulking?

One thought suddenly came to mind, and I opened my mouth in an earnest yet cautious voice.

“Mimi… Mimi-chan?”

Hiss-rik! Hiss-ririk!

Only then did the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake—or rather, Mimi-chan—nod in satisfaction and extend its tail toward me as if telling me to grab on.

Right on cue, someone shouted from far away.

“Mimi! Rescue Benefactor!”

Hiss-rik!

“…”

Yeah, fuck it. I didn’t care what the move was called. Just get me out of here.

I sat on a damp rock and stared at the rippling water.

Two people. Only two.

Of the countless people who had buried their bones in Dongting Lake today, the two I had saved were the only survivors.

…Only two out of all those people.

I had suspected it from the moment the Quest was completed, but reality was even more brutal and merciless than I had imagined.

And the countless deaths left behind by today’s tragedy had given rise to even greater sorrow.

“Ugh…”

“Sniff, sob!”

“Oh, poor Chil-Sam’s father!”

“What kind of monstrous bastard could have done this?”

By then, over a thousand people had gathered along the shore of Dongting Lake, giving voice to every kind of emotion.

A Confucian scholar lamented, unable to continue speaking. Behind a government soldier clutching a fallen comrade’s corpse and weeping came the wails of a woman with an infant strapped to her back. An old man, the veins standing out on his neck, even swung his long-stemmed tobacco pipe at some unseen culprit.

There was no longer any laughter or singing to be found at Dongting Lake, one of the most famous scenic sites under heaven.

Only the sorrow and lamentation of those left behind remained, along with the anger carried in all those emotions.

But nothing changed.

The waters of Dongting Lake had grown calm, as if nothing had happened, while the faint dawn mist spreading across the lake created a beautiful scene.

Is this what the Wuling Peach Blossom Spring, where immortals are said to live, looks like?

I stared silently at the scene before me, then spoke without warning.

“This feels like… something, doesn’t it?”

I was not talking to myself.

Cheongpung, who had not left my side for more than fifteen minutes, answered,

“Yes. It feels like shit.”

Under normal circumstances, I would have snorted with laughter despite myself. But now, there was only emptiness.

I fidgeted with a pebble and asked,

“I only said ‘something.‘ I didn’t know Cheongpung knew how to swear.”

“I didn’t at first, but I know a little now. I learned by watching someone.”

“You’d better keep that a secret from Great Hero Mae Jonghak.”

“Why, Benefactor?”

“Why do you think? How would you feel if Mimi suddenly called you a fucking bastard one day?”

“Hmm. I don’t think I’d like it.”

“…Wouldn’t most people be surprised that a snake was talking before getting angry? Either way, you’d be surprised and angry. Great Hero Mae Jonghak would feel the same.”

“Oh. I see.”

“Yeah. That’s how it is.”

“What should I do if I accidentally swear in front of Grandpa?”

“Say Gung Gibang taught you. Or Hyuk Mujin.”

“Okay.”

Silence descended.

That conversation had been nothing more than whatever nonsense came to mind. I had felt that I needed to say something—anything. Maybe doing so would make things a little better.

Both Cheongpung and I knew the truth.

We also knew that none of this would make us feel any better.

“Fuck…”

I muttered the curse like a lament.

I did not know whether today was simply an unusual day, or whether those creatures also understood the circumstances and were grieving.

There was no birdsong.

Only the wails and sobs of the people filled the air around us.

I listened quietly to those stifling, unbearable sounds, then clenched the pebble in my palm as hard as I could.

Crack. Crunch.

A handful of powder spilled from my fist.

No—it was carried by a breeze that had blown in from somewhere and settled lightly on the surface of the water.

As if they were mortal remains imbued with someone's spirit.

Cheongpung watched in silence before suddenly speaking.

"Benefactor."

"What?"

"What should I do at times like this?"

"…"

"So many people have died. In Henan, in Sichuan, at Donghu Stronghold, and today, here."

His voice trembled faintly as he continued.

"I keep thinking about the dead. And I get angry. I hate the people who keep killing others, and I feel pathetic because I can't do anything."

"…I was like that too. No, I still am."

"What did you do whenever you felt this way, Benefactor?"

"Me?"

I turned my head and finally met Cheongpung's gaze.

His usually crystal-clear eyes were swirling with a mixture of emotions.

Within that confusion, I saw my past self—and the present me staring at Cheongpung now.

Was I like this?

The person I saw reflected in Cheongpung's eyes was simply impassive.

I was not exhausted like Gung Gibang or Hyuk Mujin, nor was I trembling with anger and sorrow like those who had lost their families and companions.

No, it was not that I could no longer feel emotions.

I had merely learned to contain them.

There I stood, like a rock battered again and again over the years, worn and ground down until it had finally grown accustomed to the blows.

"Who knows? What did I do back then?"

After thinking for a moment, I slowly continued.

"I wasn't any different from you, Cheongpung. I swore nonstop at those bastards who deserved to die, blamed myself for my helplessness, and then made a vow."

"A vow?"

"Yeah. A vow."

I raised a finger and pointed at the grieving people and the corpses laid out along the shore.

“I vowed to kill every last bastard who did this. That was my vow.”

“…!”

“I’m no saint. I won’t be satisfied until I pay them back at least in equal measure. This time is no different.”

The words slipped from my lips in a dry, cold voice that sounded foreign, almost as if it belonged to someone else.

Just then—

“Captain.”

Hyuk Mujin approached us, exhaustion plainly visible on his face.

“The survivors have regained consciousness.”

“That’s good. Both of them?”

“No, sir. Only one of them, for now.”

It was unfortunate, but I had suspected as much. The treatment I had given them after the rescue had only been an emergency measure.

“Then let’s go.”

“Yes, sir. This way.”

Cheongpung and I followed Hyuk Mujin.

At last, we came face-to-face with the survivor who had regained consciousness.

“We’ve met again rather quickly, haven’t we?”

At my greeting, Honglan, the dazzlingly beautiful singing courtesan, bowed with the utmost respect.

“It is an honor to see you, Benefactor.”

Chapter 459

A flower's natural beauty does not fade merely because it has been drenched in water.

The same was true of Honglan. She looked haggard after everything she had endured, yet even so, she was as lovely as a hydrangea blossom.

"It is an honor to see you, Benefactor."

At that moment, I finally understood what people meant when they described a voice as sounding like rolling jade beads.

Her face, bare of makeup, was dazzlingly fair, and beneath her long lashes shone two eyes like morning stars.

"Good heavens."

"How can anyone be this beautiful…?"

Exclamations rose from every direction.

Those admiring Honglan's beauty hurriedly closed their mouths and left when they noticed my gaze.

Perhaps they were ashamed of behaving that way while hundreds of people had been drowned.

Then again, it also showed just how extraordinary Honglan's beauty was—that it could make them forget everything that had happened.

If we weren't in a situation like this, I wouldn't have been any different.

I composed myself and spoke.

"I'm glad you regained consciousness. How are you feeling?"

Honglan lowered her head slightly before answering.

"Although I cannot compare to my Benefactor, this lowly woman has also trained in martial arts. I do not seem to have much trouble moving."

From what I had sensed, her martial arts barely qualified as First Rate.

She might not have been skilled enough to be called a seasoned First Rate master, but a martial artist who had strengthened her body and cultivated internal energy possessed far greater vitality than any ordinary civilian.

Thank heavens.

Honglan's being a martial artist had been a stroke of incredible luck, both for her and for the other survivor we had rescued with her.

I asked the military officer who was still standing nearby,

"Where is Ju Wongong?"

Ju Wongong. A carefree distant relative of the imperial family who had taken a pleasure boat out onto Dongting Lake despite the troubled mood of the times.

He was the other survivor.

“If you mean Young Master Ju, we placed him under heavy guard and moved him somewhere safe. According to the physician, he is out of immediate danger, but no one can say when he will regain consciousness.”

He was the same military officer who had been directing everyone when we first arrived at Dongting Lake.

Responsible for the security and defense of Dongting Lake, one of the major areas of Hubei Province, he continued with a rigid expression.

“When we reported what happened, the City Lord was furious. Though the attempt failed, trying to assassinate a member of the imperial family is among the gravest of crimes. We will immediately mobilize the entire fleet and every soldier in the city to make an example of these insolent rebels—”

“Assassinating a member of the imperial family wasn’t their objective.”

“What?”

I stared at the confused officer and continued.

“They’re called Dark Heaven. You may have heard of them.”

“Dark Heaven…? Aren’t they a gang of thugs that has been causing trouble in the martial world recently?”

“A gang of thugs?”

A scoff escaped me at his choice of words.

Dark Heaven’s name had begun spreading among ordinary people after the Shaolin Bloodshed, but the officer before me had no idea how powerful or terrifying they truly were.

Gung Gibang, standing beside me, spoke with an incredulous expression.

“Officer, did you know that this ‘gang of thugs’ killed Master Hong Dao, the Abbot of Shaolin Temple[2174] and the Dharma King?”

“Th-that…”

“The Poison King, Great Hero Tang Sadok, the Grand Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, was killed too. So was the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun of Emei Sect. Three Supreme Peak masters of the previous generation who once shook the martial world, along with more than two thousand martial artists, are dead. And you call them a gang of thugs?”

“I-I heard those rumors, but I did not know the full extent of their power. Then are you saying Dark Heaven was responsible for this?”

“There’s a limit to how ignorant a man can be. Good grief. Even a passing mutt would laugh.”

“That’s enough.”

I raised a hand to stop Gung Gibang, then addressed the officer, whose face had turned red with embarrassment.

[2174] Shaolin Temple is a Buddhist monastery known for its martial arts tradition.

“Regardless, my point is that Ju Wongong was not their target.”

“Th-then what makes you think that?”

“If Dark Heaven had wanted Ju Wongong dead, he would already be gone from this world.”

“…!”

“If they wanted to kill him, they could have done it any way they pleased. He couldn’t have stopped them even if they ambushed him in broad daylight. Why wait until he took a pleasure boat out onto Dongting Lake, then destroy it along with all the other vessels? Why not even confirm whether their target was dead or alive?”

To Dark Heaven, Ju Wongong’s life was like an object in a cloth bundle—something they could take out or put away whenever they pleased.

Besides, there was no particular reason for them to target a distant imperial relative who had committed a crime and been exiled.

If their goal was to create chaos, the Emperor or Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao would have been far more attractive targets.

I spoke firmly.

“Their objective wasn’t to assassinate a member of the imperial family. Ju Wongong was merely one of the fish that happened to get caught in the net they cast.”

“Then what in the world were they after…?”

“We’ll find out once we catch the culprit.”

“What?”

“I mean the culprit who carried this out directly. Dark Heaven being behind everything is already a foregone conclusion.”

The officer had been staring blankly with his mouth open. Now he hurriedly asked,

“G-Great Hero, are you saying you know who the culprit is?”

“There is someone I suspect, but testimony from someone who saw it happen firsthand would be more reliable.”

I turned my head and looked at Honglan.

With Ju Wongong hovering between life and death, she was the only witness who held the key to unraveling everything.

“Did you see the culprit?”

The question was brief, but it was enough. With everyone’s eyes fixed on her, Honglan’s red lips slowly parted.

“Yes.”

“…!”

“…!”

Shock and agitation spread through the room in an instant. Amid the commotion, I clenched my fist tightly.

Finally.

The string of incidents that had begun with the Sea Serpent Society. The bastard—or bastards—behind them had never shown so much as a hair.

Now they were finally beginning to reveal themselves.

I couldn't let go of this tail now that I had found it. I had to seize it with all my strength, drag the body out after it, and finish the job.

Remembering the countless corpses they had left behind, I asked again.

"Tell us exactly what you saw."

"It was…"

A shallow furrow appeared on Honglan's smooth, unlined brow.

She seemed to be recalling what had happened. After hesitating for a moment and steadying her breathing, she began to speak.

"Everything happened in an instant. The festivities were in full swing when the two military vessels nearby sank one after the other, only moments apart. That was how it began."

I listened closely to Honglan's story.

Ju Wongong might have been a distant relative, but he was still a member of the imperial family. The two military ships assigned to escort him had been overwhelmed by a sudden ambush, and the pleasure boat, where the festivities had been reaching their peak, had fallen into chaos as well.

"But no one could stop it. Nothing was visible, yet the ship suddenly tilted with a tremendous roar. Then a single streak of Force flew in from somewhere and swept through the vessel. That was all it took."

"Force…!"

"I am certain. That single attack killed most of the Peak masters guarding Young Master Ju and the martial artists of Qingxia Hall.[2175]"

The scene seemed to unfold before my eyes.

Nothing was more destructive than Force. Even someone who had never seen it before would recognize that dazzling light for what it was the moment they faced it.

The same was true of Honglan, and it must have been an attack that Ju Wongong's guards and the bumbling martial artists of Qingxia Hall[2176] had been powerless to stop.

Perhaps because she was recalling that horrifying moment, Honglan's voice began to tremble faintly.

[2175] Qingxia Hall is an unofficial Hubei social club formed by the children of influential families.

[2176] Qingxia Hall is an unofficial Hubei social club formed by the children of influential families.

“But in the final moment, the guards risked their lives to push Young Master Ju away, and I embraced him before throwing myself into the river.”

Honglan’s quick thinking had saved both her and Ju Wongong.

Most of those who froze in terror were slaughtered soon afterward. Those who were still breathing could not long endure the bitter cold of the night or the injuries they had suffered in the fall.

And then…

Honglan said that, through the black waters of Dongting Lake, she had seen something rapidly receding into the distance.

“It was a person. Just one.”

“…!”

The tail had finally revealed itself. I bit my lip hard and asked again.

“Are you certain?”

“How could I lie to you, Benefactor? It was only for the briefest moment, but I saw him clearly with my own two eyes.”

Honglan was the sole witness, and she was also a martial artist who had reached the First Rate realm. If she was that certain, it was highly likely to be true.

That’s right. It was him.

Just as one man came to mind, the military officer, who had been listening with a dazed expression, abruptly spoke.

“A-are you all out of your minds? No matter how powerful martial artists may be, this is not land. This is Dongting Lake! Dongting Lake is as deep and vast as the open sea!”

“Does anyone here not know that?”

Gung Gibang muttered the words like a sigh, while Hyuk Mujin clicked his tongue.

“And?”

“What do you mean, ‘and’? I have heard plenty about the miraculous abilities of martial artists like you, but this is absurd! Even the water bandits of the Yangtze River Channel League whom I encountered from time to time were never capable of such feats. How could anyone swim so quickly across such a vast expanse of water, much less sink dozens of vessels single-handedly, including the Great Nation’s military vessels—”

“He could. If he is the man I’m thinking of.”

A clear voice rang out. Under everyone’s gaze, Honglan slowly parted her lips.

“He is a master of water arts who can breathe like a fish, swim faster than one, and easily sink dozens of vessels by himself. I do not know how formidable the water bandits you encountered may have been, but here on Dongting Lake, even the Seafaring King himself could not stand against him.”

Honglan’s gaze turned toward the blue-green waters beyond the camp.

Dongting Lake. A scenic site known throughout the land for its long history and beautiful landscapes.

And one old fisherman who had guarded Dongting Lake all his life.

No.

A Supreme Peak master of the previous generation, and a master of water arts who stood shoulder to shoulder with the Seafaring King.

I quietly murmured his alias.

“The Dongting Fisherman.”

“…!”

The Lower District Sect’s information had been correct. The Dongting Fisherman had not yet left Hubei Province.

He had faked his death and remained here at Dongting Lake, hiding in plain sight while evading everyone’s suspicion and attention.

And at last, I had found Dark Heaven’s tail—the Dongting Fisherman.

I’ve finally made it this far. You damn old bastard.

We had already paid far too high a price in lives. Before any more time passed, I had to capture the Dongting Fisherman and uncover every detail of Dark Heaven’s movements and plans.

It was the only way to prevent an even greater tragedy.

That was why Honglan’s next words were like a torch lighting the path ahead.

“Did you know, Benefactor, that the Dongting Fisherman has hidden secret refuges throughout Dongting Lake?”

“Are you saying you might know where they are?”

“I do not know their exact locations, but I know several places where they might be. Once you have finished preparing, please tell me. This humble woman can guide you there herself.”

“…!”

I clenched my fist tightly. Then I immediately sprang to my feet.

“Let’s go. Right now.”

Chapter 460

The weather was bad in more ways than one.

The waters of Dongting Lake, which had swallowed dozens of vessels and claimed lives overnight, were rough, and the wind blowing in from the distance was violent.

Even the old boatman who knew Dongting Lake like the back of his hand seemed to think that setting out in such weather was a terrible idea.

“I—I can’t do it, sirs.”

Those were the first words from the boatman, who had clearly been dragged here against his will. He continued with an anxious look on his face.

“The places you wish to visit are unusually narrow, with treacherous currents even by Dongting Lake’s standards… In weather like this, it’s simply impossible.”

“That is precisely why we are asking for your help. Merchant ships and military vessels may not be able to enter, but a sturdy ferryboat piloted by the finest boatman on Dongting Lake should manage it.”

“No matter how you put it…”

“Boatman?”

“Y-yes?”

“Please.”

A man was still a man, no matter how old he got.

Dazed by Honglan’s gentle voice and dazzling beauty, the old boatman did not come to his senses until after he had climbed aboard the ferryboat.

“I must be mad. Completely mad. I know what happened last night, yet here I am, about to set out on the water. What will I do if we run into the Hidden Shadow Ghost…?”

The Hidden Shadow Ghost?

An unfamiliar name had slipped into his grumbling. I turned and found the terrified boatman staring back at me.

He swallowed hard before answering.

“Just as the name suggests, it’s a ghostly creature. Plenty of boatmen have fallen victim to it lately. One was an old friend of mine. He went out at night hoping to earn a few extra coins, and then…”

The old boatman stared at the rippling waters of Dongting Lake with eyes steeped in fear.

“They call it the Hidden Shadow Ghost because its victims die without ever seeing so much as its shadow. This is only the humble opinion of an old man, but it must be responsible for everything that’s been happening lately. All of it is the work of that evil spirit.”

Gung Gibang clicked his tongue and cut in.

“Evil spirit, my ass. Listen, boatman. Do you think I’ve only heard stories like this once or twice? If all those tales were true, half the fish under heaven would have human faces, and the mountains would be crawling with thousand-year-old white tigers and dragons.”

“I swear there isn’t a word of falsehood in it. With one heaven-defying atrocity after another, the Divine Spirit of Dongting Lake must have been angered.”

“An evil spirit wasn’t enough, so now there’s a divine spirit too? Forget it. Let’s stop talking.”

“But every boatman in Hubei Province has heard the story…”

“Do I look like a boatman to you?”

“N-no, sir. Anyone can see you’re the most beggarly of beggars.”

“Ah, he’s not wrong, but now I’m suddenly pissed off.”

“P-please calm yourself, honored sir. This old man is guilty of nothing more than repeating what he heard.”

The old boatman sounded deeply aggrieved.

He had spent his entire life as a boatman in the Murim, where all sorts of legends and superstitions were treated as fact.

Perhaps that was why he seemed firmly convinced that the recent string of gruesome incidents was the work of the evil spirit known as the Hidden Shadow Ghost.

Come to think of it, it might not be complete nonsense.

Judging by Honglan and Cheongpung’s expressions, they had reached the same conclusion.

The moment our eyes met, they both spoke at once.

“Benefactor, could it be…”

“Benefactor, could the Hidden Shadow Ghost that boatman mentioned be…”

“Wait. I know what both of you are trying to say, so you don’t need to say it. And if you absolutely insist on calling me Benefactor, take turns. It’s confusing.”

One Benefactor parrot had already been more than enough. Now there were two.

At times like this, I almost felt like I had become someone important.

Then again, Honglan had good reason after I saved her life. But was Cheongpung seriously planning to treat me as his Benefactor forever just because I had given him a few sweets when he was hungry?

I sighed and continued.

“Anyway, there’s a good chance the Hidden Shadow Ghost is the Dongting Fisherman. If not, it could be bandits taking advantage of the chaos.”

“That’s exactly what I was going to say, Benefactor.”

Not to be outdone by Cheongpung, Honglan nodded as well.

“This humble woman thinks so too, Benefactor.”

“I said one person at a time.”

Whatever the case, it was unlikely to have been a simple accident of nature.

From what we had heard, more than a few boatmen had died. The old boatman’s next words lent even more weight to our suspicions.

“Come to think of it, all the dead boatmen disappeared in roughly the same area. Hm? Wait a moment. The place you honored guests are heading toward is nearby too…”

The old boatman suddenly froze and slowly raised his head.

He looked us over one by one without a word, then quietly lowered the oar he had been holding to set off and stood up.

“Where are you going?”

At my question, the old boatman gave an awkward smile.

“Well, I seem to have forgotten to relieve myself.”

“Mujin.”

“Yes, Captain.”

“The boatman needs to pee.”

“Does he?”

By now, Hyuk Mujin and I understood each other without needing to say much.

When Mujin—practically a giant beside the old boatman—blocked his path, the boatman’s eyes grew moist like those of a calf being led to the slaughterhouse.

“Do you still need to go?”

At Hyuk Mujin’s low voice, the boatman shook his head.

“…Come to think of it, I don’t.”

“Good. We’ll let you go before whatever you fear comes to pass, so don’t worry too much.”

I felt bad for treating an old boatman this way, but an experienced guide was essential if we wanted to reach the Dongting Fisherman’s refuge.

Our destination lay along a narrow passage that could accommodate only a few ferryboats at a time.

Even if the government mobilized a fleet of a hundred ships and tens of thousands of soldiers, they would never be able to enter. They would only become a burden.

If we end up fighting the Dongting Fisherman, bringing more people will only increase the casualties.

Our best option was for the government to seal off every route between Dongting Lake and the Yangtze in case he tried to flee, while a small elite force—including Cheongpung and me—pursued and either captured or killed him.

And just as important as dealing with the Dongting Fisherman was preventing any more pointless sacrifices.

Having finished thinking it through, I abruptly spoke.

“Hyuk Mujin, Gung Gibang, Young Lady Hong. You three…”

“No.”

“Where’s that dog barking?”

“I will contribute what little strength I have.”

Their answers came before I could finish, leaving me momentarily speechless. Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang clicked their tongues at the sight.

“It’s obvious. Completely obvious.”

“I can see exactly what you’re about to say.”

“We came all this way. How could we turn back now? What kind of man would that make me?”

“I feel the same. The Successor Beggar of the mighty Beggars’ Sect cannot be frightened off by something like this.”

“Captain, whenever something looks even slightly dangerous, you always tell us to stay behind. At this point, it’s practically your defining trait. Captain’s special.”

“You’re surprisingly timid.”

“But why have you been copying everything I say, Young Hero Gung? It’s really starting to bother me.”

“You damned bastard. Why pick a fight when things were going so well? Have you lost your mind?”

“Beggars’ Sect special. Not content with picking up discarded food from inns, you pick up other people’s words too.”

“…I’ve never seen such a bastard who’s worse than a dog.”

“Regardless, I’m going with you no matter what you say, Captain. When I was young, a gifted fortune-teller read my fate and told me I would live in wealth and glory, eating well and living comfortably past the age of one hundred. There’s no way I’m dying today.”

Gung Gibang stared incredulously at Hyuk Mujin as he made this bold declaration, then shook his head.

“Forget it. I shouldn’t have said anything. And I agree with that Hyuk bastard, so don’t even think about leaving me behind. I have inherited the supreme arts of the Beggars’ Sect. Even if I’m not as strong as you or Cheongpung, protecting my own life will be no trouble.”

…

My lips moved, but I could not bring myself to speak.

When it came down to it, neither of them was someone others could afford to underestimate.

Hyuk Mujin had begun learning martial arts relatively late, yet he had grown explosively while passing through countless crises alongside me. Gung Gibang was

talented enough to become the Successor Beggar, as well as a Peak master who had entered a mature realm.

But I'm afraid.

I was afraid of losing people close to me. Afraid that what happened that day would happen all over again.

As I hesitated, Cheongpung suddenly spoke.

"Benefactor. If you go, I can follow you to the very depths of hell."

"Young Hero Cheongpung."

"Please don't tell me I can't. I am a proper man and a martial artist too."

"Young Hero Cheongpung."

Cheongpung smiled faintly and shook his head.

"Benefactor, please don't say anything. All you need to do is trust us as much as I trust you."

"No, that isn't what I meant. You're obviously coming with us, so why did you step forward and…"

"Oh. Ah…"

"Stop saying pointless things and sit down. Don't ruin the mood."

"…Yes, Benefactor."

A quiet laugh escaped me at his crestfallen expression. I nodded to Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang.

"Remember one thing. No matter what happens, follow my judgment. Even if I order you to abandon me and run."

"Captain, that…"

Gung Gibang discreetly jabbed Hyuk Mujin in the side.

"Of course. We'll remember. The Hyuk bastard will too. Right?"

"Hm? Ah, yes."

Their intentions were obvious, but I pretended not to notice.

I would do everything in my power to prevent that situation from arising. I was confident I could separate them before they fell into danger.

But the last person posed a problem.

"You already know what I'm going to say, don't you?"

Honglan's red lips slowly parted.

"You will need someone who knows the exact route."

"We'll be fine. According to you, Young Lady Hong, the finest boatman on Dongting Lake is already with us."

"What if something unexpected happens?"

"We'll deal with it."

“I may be insignificant compared to you and the others, but I too have reached the First Rate realm…”

“I know. And I also know that this First Rate master spent several shichen[2177] submerged in the river while holding on to a strong man, and has only been conscious for half a shichen.”

“…!”

Honglan bit down softly on her lip, struck where it hurt.

She knew better than anyone.

Being able to move around as she did now and fighting a fierce battle were two entirely different things.

“Once again, it seems all I can do is watch.”

“Once again?”

“Yes. Back then, long ago. Last night. And now.”

Reading the question in my eyes, Honglan smiled. It was more bitter than any smile I had seen from her before.

“A great many things happened before a little girl who lost her clan and her parents overnight could become the woman she is today…”

“Ah.”

“Please excuse me for a moment.”

She looked up at me with shining eyes and quietly reached out a hand.

Her pale, slender fingers brushed through my tangled hair and grazed my neck. I flinched despite myself.

“Young Lady Hong, what are you…”

“All done. Ah, much better. Would you like to see?”

I followed Honglan’s fingers with my gaze and looked down at the clear waters of Dongting Lake.

Someone’s reflection floated on the surface.

My hair had been neatly arranged and secured with a beautiful silver hairpin.

When I raised my head, Honglan was smiling brightly.

“Benefactor—no, Great Hero Jin.”

Her hair, now unbound, swayed gently in the wind. It rippled and shimmered until it seemed almost radiant.

“I wish you good fortune in battle.”

Her quiet voice slowly faded from my ears.

Leaving Honglan behind, the boatman drove his oar powerfully through the water.

[2177] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

Chapter 461

When it came to speed, a ferryboat couldn't match the Yangtze River Channel League's swift ships—or even an ordinary vessel. Especially in weather as foul as today's.

Hoooooosh! Splash!

The ferryboat rocked in the fierce wind and churning current.

Its small hull offered little resistance to the elements. Veins bulged along the arms of the old boatman gripping the oars.

As befitted an experienced boatman, he had guided the ferryboat skillfully despite the bad weather. But the closer we came to our destination, the more violent the current grew, and he was nearing his limit.

This is probably as far as he can take us.

It would have been insane to come this far relying on nothing but a single ferryboat and an old boatman.

I rolled my neck from side to side and stepped forward.

"Shall we begin?"

At those words, three people opened their eyes. They had been circulating their qi without moving an inch despite the rocking hull.

"I'm ready, Benefactor."

"To use one of the Beggars' Sect's finest arts for something like this… Master would certainly have a thing or two to say if he saw me."

"Captain, what should I do?"

Cheongpung, Gung Gibang, and Hyuk Mujin had replenished their qi. I quickly gave them their orders.

"Cheongpung, follow me to the stern. Gung Gibang, take the bow. Mujin, protect the boatman. I'll call when I need you, so move the instant I do."

As the three took their positions, the old boatman, who had been struggling at the oars, blinked.

"E-excuse me, what exactly are you talking about…?"

Before he could finish, a fierce blast of palm force shot from Cheongpung's hands and slammed into the water.

Boom! Fwooooooosh!

"Waaaaaagh!"

The so-called palm-force booster.

The ferryboat was far smaller and lighter than even the sleek-hulled swift ships. It soared through the air.

The boatman's scream mingled with the wind tearing past us.

Using that scream as my signal, I stepped forward.

Now.

Whoooosh!

Just as the airborne ferryboat was about to drop back onto the water, I drew up the internal energy filling my dantian and sent it surging into my palms.

Boom! Booooom!

My Flame Divine Palm had now reached eighty percent mastery. Its heat made the surrounding air blaze, and the descending ferryboat leaped upward again like a flying fish.

The boatman's eyes bulged. He pointed ahead with a trembling finger.

"Reefs! There are reeeefs ahead!"

Did anyone really think the Dongting Fisherman would establish one of his secret refuges somewhere easy to reach?

The route we were taking was too narrow for ordinary vessels to enter. The current was also unusually strong, making it difficult for a light boat like a ferryboat to escape once it was caught in the flow.

Once the current swept a boat away, it would be easy for it to crash against one of the reefs scattered throughout the passage.

"You fucking bastards! I told you I wasn't coming!"

The old boatman's heartfelt scream rang out. At that exact moment, I shouted a name.

"Gung Gibang!"

"Got it!"

Gung Gibang answered energetically and flung his sleeves, which were little more than rags.

The Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms—said to be passed down to only two people among the Beggars' Sect's hundred thousand disciples, the Sect Leader and the Successor Beggar—erupted through the air.

Kwoooooo-boooom!

Palm force poured down like a rainstorm, shattering the reef that towered like an iron wall into countless fragments.

The second and third reefs that appeared beyond it could not withstand the might of the Eighteen Dragon-Subduing Palms either.

Kraaaaaash!

The ferryboat broke through the scattered fragments of reef and landed on the surface.

Spray surged up on both sides of the hull, and several fish that had leaped from somewhere slapped the old boatman across the cheeks.

"Gah… Uhhh…"

He was completely out of it.

I shook the drooling boatman by the shoulder. His eyes had gone half vacant.

“Wake up. Stay with us.”

“Ugh… Uhhh. You fucking…”

“This isn’t working. Mujin.”

“By your command.”

Hyuk Mujin rolled up both sleeves and planted a solid slap across the boatman’s face.

Smack!

The boatman’s eyes snapped back into focus.

“Gah! What was that—”

Smack!

“…I-I’m already awake.”

“Stop.”

“Yes, sir.”

Nothing brought someone to their senses like a good slap across the face.

I turned to the boatman as he rubbed his reddened cheeks.

“Where do you think we are?”

“No matter how honored you gentlemen may be, treating a man like this is—”

“Mujin.”

“By your command.”

“I’ll check immediately, sir.”

The boatman sprang to his feet and looked around.

The channel was barely wide enough for two or three ferryboats to pass side by side.

Sheer cliffs loomed on either bank, and violent currents churned across the water. Thick fog hung over everything.

The old boatman narrowed his eyes and carefully examined the area before nodding.

“Yes. This is the first of the places you mentioned.”

According to the Lower District Sect’s information Honglan had relayed to us, there were five likely locations for the Dongting Fisherman’s secret refuge.

We had reached the closest of them.

That was certainly good news, but it was too early to celebrate.

“Getting here quickly is all well and good, but… how are we supposed to find it now?”

At Gung Gibang’s question, I scanned our surroundings.

“I don’t know. The information Young Lady Hong gave us wasn’t exact, either. We’ll have to search the area thoroughly.”

"Ugh. This is going to take forever."

"Don't jinx us. Just be grateful Young Lady Hong's information got us this far."

A secret refuge wasn't called a secret refuge for nothing.

Honglan's information had not included its exact location, but merely narrowing down the Dongting Fisherman's hidden retreat to this area was already a major gain.

Even if the first location turned out to be a dead end, something would eventually be caught once we drew the net tight enough.

Unless it jumps out on its own before we catch it.

As I carefully surveyed the area, my face suddenly began to prickle.

I glanced aside. Four pairs of eyes had been staring at me strangely, but they immediately darted away.

"What?"

"W-what do you mean? I was just… thinking it was nice that you were still thinking about Young Lady Hong in the middle of all this."

"Ahem. Captain, you have my full support."

"Ah, youth is a fine thing. I was popular with the ladies myself until about thirty years ago. They used to call me the Fisher of Women's Hearts on Dongting Lake. Hahaha."

"…"

It was obvious what they were all thinking.

I was inwardly clicking my tongue when my eyes happened to meet Cheongpung's. He flinched like a bird that had been shot and frantically waved both hands.

"No! No, Benefactor! I wasn't thinking about anything!"

"What on earth were you thinking about? I haven't even said anything yet."

"Really, I wasn't! I swear I wasn't imagining Young Lady Hong and Benefactor falling passionately in love, getting married, having two children, and living happily ever after! Or imagining myself living next door and visiting Benefactor all the time!"

"…"

"Gasp!"

Only then did Cheongpung realize his mistake. He clapped both hands over his mouth, but it was already too late.

He imagined all that in the space of a few seconds?

At that rate, he could quit being a martial artist and become a novelist.

His pen name could be Huashan Divine Dragon. If he published under Huashan's name and got Sword Saint Mae Jonghak to write a blurb, his books would sell like crazy.

Of course, if he made me the protagonist, he would get the shit beaten out of him just as quickly.

"Good grief. What is wrong with you people…? Never mind. Forget it."

There was no point wasting my breath. I sighed and quickly issued new orders.

It wasn't because my face had somehow grown hot, or because the faint scent clinging to Honglan's silver hairpin kept tickling my nose.

…Really.

"Cheongpung and Gung Gibang, use the Wall Lizard Technique to search the cliffs. Mujin, take the boat around and search below. We don't know what might appear or when, so don't let your guard down for a single moment."

At my serious tone, the faint smiles vanished from everyone's lips.

If the Dongting Fisherman really was here, a fight would be unavoidable.

I did not know exactly how powerful he was, but if a Supreme Peak master of the Dongting Fisherman's caliber launched a surprise attack, Cheongpung and I were probably the only ones who could properly respond.

"Remember this. If you let your guard down, you die."

Of course, we would do everything in our power to prevent that from happening. But in the world of martial artists, life and death could be decided in an instant.

Everyone nodded gravely. I was about to turn away when Hyuk Mujin suddenly spoke.

"What are you doing?"

"We're searching together. Did you think I was going to sit around and have fun by myself?"

"No, that isn't what I meant. Weren't you planning to remain on the ferryboat?"

"Cheongpung and Gung Gibang have the cliffs covered, and you'll be searching below, so I need to look somewhere else."

"Somewhere else? Where else is there to…"

Hyuk Mujin stopped mid-sentence.

"Don't tell me…"

"That's right."

I looked down at the churning river.

"We have to search underwater too. If it were anyone else, I might not consider it, but this is the Dongting Fisherman's refuge. It's a perfectly reasonable possibility."

"But you've never learned water arts, have you?"

"Hmm. Probably not."

At my confident answer, Cheongpung and Gung Gibang—who had been about to climb the cliffs with the Wall Lizard Technique—each added a warning. Even the old boatman, holding his oar aloft like a weapon, joined in.

"Benefactor, my grandfather once told me that you must never fight a master of water arts underwater."

"I agree. You haven't learned water arts, so you couldn't possibly search this entire stretch by yourself. And if your opponent is the Dongting Fisherman, you should avoid it all the more."

"I know you are an exceptional martial artist, honored sir, but the water here is deep and the current is fierce. One wrong move, and you could truly be in grave danger."

I couldn't find a single flaw in any of their arguments.

A battle between Supreme Peak masters could be decided by the smallest detail.

And the difference between fighting on land and fighting underwater was as vast as the difference between heaven and earth.

The martial arts I've learned are particularly vulnerable underwater too.

Most of the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts were based on Scorching Yang Qi—in other words, fire qi.

By their very nature, they could not display the same power underwater as they could on land.

That was also why Jeok Cheongang hated the Yangtze so much. He knew that if a life-and-death duel broke out there, he would be fighting at a disadvantage.

"…"

Hmm. I take that back. Thinking about it again, he probably just hated water itself.

Regardless, it would not have been particularly surprising if the Dongting Fisherman had established a secret refuge underwater, away from other people's eyes and footsteps.

He was a master of water arts who could breathe like a fish and move even faster than one.

But I hadn't volunteered without a plan.

My entire swimming career consisted of a children's swimming class I had taken when I was seven. There was another reason I had decided to enter those deep, raging waters.

I've never used it before, but… if the description is accurate, this should be more than possible.

I exhaled briefly and removed my shirt and shoes.

Before Hyuk Mujin could recover from his surprise and stop me, I leaped straight into the river.

Splash! Whoooooosh!

The water was as cold as ice, yet crystal clear.

Schools of brightly colored fish swam together. Far below, unidentifiable aquatic plants swayed in the depths.

And then… at last, the sound I had been waiting for rang out.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

The Water Rescue Worker Title's effect has activated!
The special Skill embedded in the Title has been applied!
Water Rescue Worker's Webbing has been generated!
Water Rescue Worker's Gills have been generated!
The special Skill will remain active for 24 hours and cannot be used again for one week!
The martial arts you have learned are incompatible with the surrounding environment. The power of Fire Gate Clan martial arts is reduced by 20 percent underwater!

As the System notifications appeared, my body began to change.

Shhhhhhh.

A faint light visible only to me swept over my entire body. Transparent webbing formed between my fingers and toes.

This is…

Even underwater, I felt as light and mobile as I did on land.

My vision grew even clearer. When I exhaled the breath I had been holding, the cold water turned into air and rushed into my lungs.

This works even better than I expected.

I had never imagined the **Water Rescue Worker** Title I'd earned by completing the sudden Quest *The Tragedy of Dongting Lake* would prove useful so soon.

This should be more than enough.

Grinning, I began to swim smoothly.

My transparent webbing sliced through the fierce current, propelling me into the distance faster than a fish.

Chapter 462

The old boatman could not believe what was happening before his eyes.

What in the world is going on?

He had worked as a boatman for nearly forty years, ever since he was around twenty, but in all that time, he had never experienced anything as bizarre as this.

Tap-tap-tap-tap!

Two figures raced across the sheer cliff above him. It was not the first time he had seen them today, but the sight amazed him every time.

The boatman stared upward, his mouth hanging open.

Are those apes or people?

He had encountered countless martial artists during his years as a boatman, but this was the first time he had ever witnessed such astonishing martial arts firsthand.

Most of the martial artists who used his ferryboat were wandering martial artists with mediocre skills and shallow pockets, or disciples of small and middling sects.

I had my suspicions when the government troops suddenly showed up and ordered me to follow them…

He had seen it clearly: Officer Gwak, who was in charge of Dongting Lake, had been visibly flustered as he addressed these people with honorifics.

Considering how arrogant the man usually was, there was no doubt that today's passengers were important figures who carried considerable weight even in the Murim.

If this goes well, I might make a tidy sum.

He had been considering retirement lately. Whenever he heard about the nonstop tragedies of the past month, unease had settled in one corner of his heart, and his old bones had begun aching more than usual.

He had nearly made up his mind after hearing that hundreds of people had been slaughtered en masse on Dongting Lake the previous night.

The spirit of Dongting Lake must have grown enraged. The heavenly patterns are ominous, so evil spirits like the Hidden Shadow Ghost are running wild.

Boatmen were famous for believing in all sorts of superstitions, and old men were prone to retelling legends as though they were facts.

It was only natural that a man who had spent his entire life as a boatman—and had grown old doing it—would decide to retire.

But if important people were calling for him, what choice did he have? When they had dragged him away like a criminal and ordered him to launch the ferryboat, he had been prepared to die.

Tap-tap-tap-tap!

But seeing those figures filled him with hope.

Hope that he could survive, of course, but also that he might make enough money to retire in comfort.

They must possess incredible martial arts!

They said martial masters of the highest realms could fold the earth beneath their feet and walk through the air.

What those people were doing was not much different from the rumors the old boatman had heard secondhand.

Even the young man who seemed to be their leader was cutting through the rough water as though he were a fish.

No, that's not right. This is already the fourth location. He isn't like a fish—he is a fish.

What kind of human being had webbed feet and gills? Whenever that young man entered the water, he stayed under for at least a full shichen.[2178]

He had already repeated that impossible feat three times. If anyone deserved to be called a martial master, it was him.

Masters like these could deal with some miscellaneous Fiend like the Hidden Shadow Ghost in an instant.

If he could only make it out alive, retiring with a fortune would be easy.

Just as the old boatman was brimming with hope, a shout rang out from the cliff above.

"Young Hero Cheongpung! Is there anything over there?"

"I'll tell you when I see something!"

"If you find anything, tell us right away!"

"Yes, I certainly will… Ah!"

"Gasp! What is it? What happened?"

A heavy tension abruptly settled over the area.

Hyuk Mujin, who was scanning the surroundings from the slowly moving ferryboat, swallowed hard. So did Gung Gibang, whose eyes were gleaming sharply from the opposite cliff.

Then, under everyone's gaze, Cheongpung shouted,

"Wow, it's a swallow's nest! I've never seen one this big before!"

"…"

"…"

"…"

The air froze solid.

The boatman suddenly thought,

[2178] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

…Spirit of Dongting Lake, please protect this old man.

At this rate, he was about to lose what little faith he had left in them.

While the old boatman prayed to the spirit without anyone knowing, it happened.

Splash! Tap!

A shadow shot out of the water amid a spray of droplets and landed lightly on the ferryboat.

The figure had a build large enough to be called massive, with flexible muscles that looked as hard as steel. A beautiful silver hairpin that suited him strangely well held his disheveled hair in place.

“Welcome back.”

At Hyuk Mujin’s greeting, Jin Taekyung silently nodded.

Seeing his furrowed brow, the old boatman cautiously asked,

“Nothing this time either?”

It was a pointless question. If he had found something, his expression would not have been so dark.

Jin Taekyung stood deep in thought, his brows drawn together, before finally speaking.

“This is the fourth location, right?”

“Yes, that it is.”

The old boatman answered while carefully watching Taekyung’s mood.

These incredible passengers had already come up empty-handed three times. Including this place, they had now failed to find anything at four locations.

Riding in the same boat as martial masters in a foul mood was hardly pleasant.

The one thing that was both fortunate and unfortunate was that one final location remained.

Fwoosh. Hissss!

Jin Taekyung lightly circulated his internal energy, evaporating the water clinging to him, and asked,

“How long will it take to reach the last location?”

“If we continue the way we have been, half an hour should be enough. But…”

The old boatman swallowed before continuing.

“The wind and current are growing stronger the farther we go. It’ll be getting dark by the time we arrive, so perhaps it would be better to try another day.”

“No. It has to be today.”

“But…”

“We have to go. Right now.”

His tone was as sharp and decisive as a knife stroke. The old boatman closed his mouth.

For some reason, the weather was ominously foul today. The sky, which should have been clear, was choked with dark clouds, while the fierce wind and current showed no sign of settling down.

I've got a bad feeling about this.

The foreboding he had felt only in the past, when floods or storms were bearing down on them, pricked at every inch of the veteran boatman's body.

But he forced himself to ignore the unease seeping into his chest.

Have I grown timid with age? No, that can't be it.

A sudden flood or storm? It made no sense.

Boatmen like him were more sensitive to changes in the river than anyone.

The current had certainly grown unusually rough over the past month, but it was not the rainy season. A disaster of that scale was impossible.

The boatman was still mulling it over when he realized that a large hand had settled on his shoulder.

"Boatman. Aren't you going?"

"…I'm going."

At Hyuk Mujin's weighty voice, the boatman slowly began turning the ferryboat.

Of course, he did not forget to curse inwardly at the rude fellow who looked like the weakest of the group.

"Boatman. Were you cursing me just now?"

"…!"

The boatman's oar slipped, and the ferryboat rocked.

The rapids had grown even rougher than when they first set out, dragging at the small hull. Jin Taekyung stepped forward and swept both palms outward.

Boom!

The ferryboat regained its balance and surged ahead.

As Taekyung gazed at the gradually darkening sky, his eyes grew somber.

Did we get it wrong?

The information Honglan had passed on from the Lower District Sect pointed to five locations in total.

But even after searching thoroughly above and below the water, they had found no trace of the Dongting Fisherman's secret refuge.

After coming up empty-handed one place after another, it was only natural to wonder whether the information had been wrong from the beginning.

Taekyung thought for a moment, then shook his head.

No. It's too early to decide that.

One final place remained. Of the five locations suspected of concealing the Dongting Fisherman's secret refuge, it was the deepest and most treacherous.

It might even have been more important than the other four combined.

If it really was the Dongting Fisherman's refuge—and if they encountered him there…

It'll be a life-and-death duel. We'll have to fight with our lives on the line.

Against a Supreme Peak master, giving everything they had was only natural. But if at all possible, they needed to capture him alive.

The true reason they were searching for the Dongting Fisherman was to reach the larger body behind him.

Dark Heaven was like a three-headed, six-armed monster. Killing the Dongting Fisherman would merely cut off one of its arms. Capturing him would give them a chance to strike at its body.

"The body. The body, huh…"

His quiet mutter scattered into the wind.

Without realizing it, Taekyung touched the silver hairpin holding back his hair and suddenly thought of one person.

He also remembered the hundreds of corpses that had filled the clear waters of Dongting Lake, and the wails of those left behind.

"I'm going to catch you, you bastards. No matter what."

A faint fragrance drifted from the silver hairpin and lingered at the tip of his nose. The bow of the ferryboat cut forcefully through the river as its waters began turning black.

Donghu Stronghold.

The largest water stronghold in Hubei, which had once wielded tremendous influence under the command of the outstanding Supreme Peak master Hwang Chung, the Yangtze One Saber, had been crowded with unfamiliar visitors for the past two days.

"Pull when I count to three. One, two. Heave!"

Some were tying logs together to make a temporary path across the river. Elsewhere, middle-aged men dressed in neat scholar's robes were writing on bamboo slips.

A young Daoist in a robe approached one of them and asked,

"Excuse me, sir. Has the search of the left cliff already been completed?"

"About half of it. I can stake our family name on the fact that we haven't found any trace of a Formation so far. How is Wudang doing?"

"The search is progressing smoothly. We are also maintaining a strict watch in case anything unexpected happens, so you need not worry."

They were disciples of the Zhuge Clan, known collectively as Divine Mechanism Zhuge, and Daoists from Wudang who had accompanied Perfected Being Hyeongong to Donghu Stronghold.

These unfamiliar visitors, who had been nowhere to be seen two days ago, had formed groups to search the cliffs and were devoting all their efforts to finding traces of Dark Heaven.

Yet even the countless eyes and ears spread throughout the area, aided by brightly burning torches, failed to notice one person.

Swish.

His movements made no sound and gave off no presence.

The small, lithe figure quietly and stealthily headed toward the cliff. He passed dozens of people at the very least, yet not one of them noticed who he was.

Nor did anyone detect the Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step, wielded by the greatest assassin in history.

What a nuisance.

Mungyeong muttered inwardly as he stepped forward.

Treading on empty air, he soared like a bird and swiftly crossed the cliff.

The stealthy search conducted by the young medical apprentice whom no one paid any attention to did not take long.

Nothing. I'm certain.

The area containing Donghu Stronghold's headquarters was vast.

It was an island capable of comfortably housing more than a thousand people. High cliffs surrounded it on every side, with narrow, undeveloped paths running along their upper reaches.

But that was all.

Nowhere could he sense any trace of human presence or the remnants of a Formation known as a Moving Formation.

That was the conclusion reached after two days of searching by a Supreme Peak master who had surpassed Returning to Simplicity and reached the realm of Returned to Youth.

Mungyeong trusted his judgment. At the same time, he realized there was still one place they had not searched.

That's right. One place remains.

The river visible from the cliff was unusually wide and deep.

Deep enough that even he had no desire to enter it.

…I suppose I have no choice.

It was a way to prevent an even greater sacrifice.

The face of the old disciple he had parted from on an unnamed hill overlooking the Sichuan Tang Clan flashed before his eyes.

All right, you rascal.

Mungyeong quietly threw himself into the air.

His figure slipped deep into the river as though melting into the water, then glided smoothly toward the depths.

Chapter 463

Deep within a dark cave where only a faint light seeped in, a small old man sat cross-legged in quiet contemplation.

Energy like the sun raced through hundreds of acupoints and into the Eight Extraordinary Meridians.[2179] It took on physical form, rising to envelop the old man's entire body.

Then the changes began.

Whooooooosh.

Three flower buds bloomed above the old man's snow-white hair, then vanished.

As the buds formed, the energy they scattered took on a new shape: five rings radiant with dazzling, multicolored light.

It was a phenomenon that could only be displayed by one of the chosen few among Supreme Peak masters who had reached the realm of Five Qi Returning to Origin.

But the changes surrounding the old man did not end there.

Fwoosh. Hisssss!

The five rings symbolizing Five Qi Returning to Origin turned red. Tremendous fire qi erupted from the rings of internal energy brimming with Scorching Yang Qi, coiling around the old man before taking on a blue hue.

Furnace Fire Pure Blue.

When the fire in a furnace grew hot enough, it turned blue. The realm of martial arts the old man had attained was no different.

It was no exaggeration to say that the internal energy and insight he had accumulated over more than a hundred years had already reached the ultimate.

And yet…

Is this as far as I go?

The old man, Fire King Jeok Cheongang, withdrew his internal energy. His cross-legged figure descended from where it floated in midair, and the moment he touched the ground, the strange phenomena surrounding him vanished without a trace.

Only Jeok Cheongang's hollow chuckle remained in the silent cave.

"Heh heh."

Why could he not break through the wall before him and advance any farther?

He knew the reason better than anyone. He nodded in acknowledgment, yet he could not help regretting that the wall refused to budge. He even resented the heavens for it.

[2179] The Eight Extraordinary Meridians are channels through which qi is said to circulate in traditional Chinese medicine and martial-arts fiction.

But rather than furrow his brow, Jeok Cheongang soothed his bitterness with a laugh.

What is there to resent? This old man brought it upon himself.

Martial arts grew stronger through ceaseless training, while insight came only when one emptied the heart.

But Jeok Cheongang had been unable to clear away the dregs that had accumulated in his heart over the past several decades.

Anything left to pile up and stagnate would eventually rot. His rotting heart filled with worldly anguish, inviting an inner demon—and once that inner demon took hold, he could no longer ward off the infirmities of old age.

“If I hadn’t met that brat… I’d probably be smearing shit on the walls by now. Heh heh.”

Jeok Cheongang laughed heartily.

One.

If he could attain just one small insight, he might reach the realm of Returned to Youth.

But he knew that desire was greed as well. Proof that he had not completely emptied his heart.

He looked up. The sky was visible through a small opening in the cave, and Jeok Cheongang addressed someone unseen beyond it.

“Does this mean I should be satisfied with what I have? Is that it?”

No answer came.

Or perhaps he had already received one.

He had taken a born killer as his disciple and caused innocent people to die. Yet thanks to his second disciple, he had at least managed to preserve his sanity. The answer was that he should no longer cling to anything more.

No one had spoken, but Jeok Cheongang heard the answer within his own heart.

“What a fucking joke. After all the fiends this old man has dealt with, this is how I’m treated?”

Jeok Cheongang sighed in complaint, lowered his head, and continued.

“Don’t you think so?”

A man stood where his gaze came to rest. Crouching Dragon Guest[2180] Zhuge Feng waved his folding fan as he answered.

“When I was nine, my grandfather once sat me beside him and said something similar. ‘I don’t know what bastard is up there, but he must have a truly god-awful temper.‘ You are saying the same thing now, Senior.”

Jeok Cheongang nodded.

“Zhuge Gonghu did occasionally say something right.”

[2180] “Crouching Dragon” was a sobriquet of Zhuge Liang, a strategist of China’s Three Kingdoms period.

“He was a wise man.”

“He was also smarter than you. At least he didn’t have the bad manners to wave a fan in front of someone old enough to be his grandfather. Fold that thing before I break it.”

“It will not break easily. I had two nyang[2181] of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron worked into it.”

“Is your skull made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron too?”

“Ah, I see. Thank you for the lesson.”

Zhuge Feng promptly folded his fan, then looked around the cave.

“But what brings you here? The search is already over, and no one comes here anymore.”

“That is precisely why I came. This old man knows nothing about mechanisms and formations, so I have to prepare in my own way.”

At the word *prepare*, Zhuge Feng’s eyebrows rose slightly.

“You believe there will be a battle.”

“A martial artist should always be prepared for a fight. Besides, those Dark Heaven bastards are brutal and persistent. This will not end here.”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice was heavy.

Dark Heaven had taken the life of his close friend, Dharma King Hong Dao.

The countless deaths caused by the bloodshed in Henan and Sichuan were more than enough to remind him of the Great Faction War.

“I assume you know that the Heavenly Power Demon was imprisoned in the underground prison beneath the Sichuan Tang Clan.”

“Of course. I also know that before his death, he told Jin Taekyung that Dark Heaven was the successor to the Demonic Cult.”

The Great Faction War, fought for supremacy over the world, had ended in victory for the orthodox faction. But it had not been a sweeping victory. It was a victory that left nothing but wounds.

Had the orthodox faction retained enough strength at the time, it would have pursued the retreating forces of the Demonic Cult and torn out every last root.

But the Heavenly Demon Divine Cult and the orthodox faction—the dragon and tiger—had both lost most of their strength when the war ended. The long interval of more than fifty years had given the defeated survivors ample time to rise again.

Under a new name.

Dark Heaven.

“So much time has passed before we knew it. The wheel has turned, and troubled times have come again.”

At Jeok Cheongang’s quiet words, Zhuge Feng looked up.

[2181] A *nyang* is a traditional Korean unit of weight. Two nyang are approximately 75 g (2.65 oz).

The sky visible through the cracks in the cave ceiling was dark and chaotic. Even if the black clouds vanished tomorrow and the blue sky emerged, the heavenly patterns had already fallen into such disarray that no diviner in the world could read them.

Troubled times.

After completing its long circle, an age of turmoil had returned. An era of calamity was already upon them.

Blood would flow in rivers, and corpses would pile up like mountains.

Death and destruction would run rampant. Orphans who had lost their parents would wander the world, while plague and famine spread because there would be no one to dispose of the rotting bodies.

What is happening now is only a small part of it.

As Zhuge Feng realized that once more, a chill ran down his spine.

But Dark Heaven was not the only reason.

“I see you already had a guest.”

A voice pierced his ears.

Zhuge Feng froze as though someone had dumped ice water over his head.

How?

Though he had not reached the Supreme Peak realm, Zhuge Feng was still a master standing at the very edge of Peak.

Yet he had sensed no presence. Heard no sound.

Even though he had left three guards who followed him like shadows at the entrance to the cave, he had noticed no sign of anything.

That meant the owner of the voice was at least a Supreme Peak master.

If he’s that powerful…

Aside from Jeok Cheongang, the only possibility was Perfected Being Hyeongong of Wudang.

But the voice was far too young and clear.

It sounded like a boy’s.

Ah.

Insight flashed through Zhuge Feng’s mind, and he spun around.

The moment he saw the young medical apprentice he had encountered several times in passing, the fog in his mind dispersed, and a sobriquet slipped from his lips.

“The Slaughter Saint.”

The young medical apprentice, Mungyeong, twitched an eyebrow.

“You already knew?”

“I did not. Not until just now.”

Zhuge Feng continued excitedly.

“But I have always wondered why the greatest assassin in history disappeared. I also wondered why an extraordinary healer known as the Divine Physician appeared only after the Great Faction War had ended.”

“Not bad.”

“I watched you closely once, but I never imagined that you had reached the realm of Returned to Youth.”

Almost nothing was known about the Slaughter Saint. He was a figure shrouded in mystery.

Zhuge Feng stared at Mungyeong with gleaming eyes, then suddenly hesitated.

“But why would you deliberately reveal yourself to me… Unless?”

“You’re quick. Worthy of the Zhuge bloodline.”

“Blood will tell, after all. He may be a little strange, but the boy is clever. Zhuge Gonghu raised his grandson well. Now, putting that aside…”

Jeok Cheongang shrugged and fixed his gaze on Mungyeong.

“What brings you here? Why has an old man who’s been playing at being a child, despite it not suiting him in the slightest, come rushing over?”

“I’ll keep it short. You must leave this place immediately.”

“What?”

As promised, Mungyeong’s answer was extremely brief.

And for Jeok Cheongang, it was nowhere near reason enough to brave that godforsaken Tianling Falls.

“What kind of bullshit is—”

“I should make it even shorter.”

Mungyeong continued in a low, grave voice.

“Your disciple is in danger. No—perhaps everyone is.”

“…!”

The moment he heard those words, Jeok Cheongang realized that he needed no further reason.

He turned toward Zhuge Feng. Blue flames had already kindled in his aged eyes.

“Launch the boat. Right now.”

By the time we reached the final location, the waters of Dongting Lake had turned purple.

I gazed at the sunset shining through the gaps between the cliffs and jagged rock formations, then spoke.

“Don’t move around carelessly from here on. Tie the ferryboat somewhere safe, get onto land, and prepare for anything.”

Dongting Lake was called a lake, but it was so vast that the name hardly seemed adequate.

There wasn't water in every direction. Small islands were easy enough to find, as were flat stretches of land formed by mud and sand carried in from tributaries of the Yangtze.

If a battle breaks out, fighting on land will put us at a much greater advantage.

None of us had mastered water arts.

I could at least move freely underwater thanks to the Water Rescue Worker Title, but even I could not avoid the debuff that reduced the power of my martial arts by twenty percent.

If things go badly… we need to be able to fight back on land, at the very least.

The others understood my reasoning perfectly well.

Gung Gibang spoke with a determined expression.

"I'll go with you."

"Can you swim?"

"I can dog-paddle a little."

"Go to land before you get beaten like a dog."

"Hmm. That would probably be better."

Gung Gibang stepped back, and Hyuk Mujin came forward.

"Captain."

"You stay on land too. Keep your head down and hide. You won't be any help if you charge in for no reason."

"I know. I only called out to encourage you."

"…"

What a sibu-leol[2182] bastard. I felt what little strength I had left draining away.

I let out a small sigh, then gave Cheongpung one final, earnest warning.

"The Dongting Fisherman may or may not be in there. But if I find him and drag him outside…"

Cheongpung nodded.

"I won't miss the opportunity."

"Good. That's all I need."

I had no idea just how formidable the Dongting Fisherman was, but with Cheongpung's help, things would be much easier.

Of course, he might not be here either.

But… how should I put it?

This time felt different.

It wasn't reason. It was instinct.

[2182] *Sibu-leol* is a colloquial Korean profanity, roughly equivalent to "fucking."

I looked at each of them in turn, then leaped without hesitation into the purple water.

Splash!

The familiar sensation washed over me as a System notification rang out.

The Title's effect activated. Transparent webbing formed between my fingers and toes, and breathing became easy.

Deeper. Farther in.

I pressed onward without stopping.

I swam swiftly through the cold water, passing countless fish.

Then I spotted something in the distance.

What's that…?

Far ahead, a pitch-black cave came into view.

Chapter 464

Dongting Lake was unquestionably a lake, but it covered a thousand *li*[2183], and even at its shallowest, the water was easily more than ten *zhang*[2184] deep.

The place I was swimming through now was one of the deepest parts of Dongting Lake. Naturally, the water was much deeper here, and the current raged like waves.

Finding a small underwater cave under these conditions was nothing short of heaven-sent luck.

That's…

Amid the countless schools of fish, I spotted a gap barely wide enough for a grown man to squeeze through.

A thrill ran down my spine.

I found it.

Cliffs rooted deep in a riverbed naturally split apart over the years through sedimentation and erosion. I had seen it several times at the four places we had already visited.

But this time was different.

My reason and instinct, which usually went their separate ways, were whispering the same thing.

The Dongting Fisherman's secret refuge.

Everything left traces.

The difference was subtle and well concealed, but my accumulated experience and keen eyesight told me that human hands had touched the entrance slowly drawing closer.

The edges are smooth. Someone definitely worked on them.

There was no need to ask who.

I heightened every one of my senses to the limit and cut through the current.

Slowly. Carefully.

It would be stupid to announce my presence to an enemy with whom I would soon be locked in a life-and-death duel.

If he prepared himself, the situation would become even more unfavorable.

Fortunately, there's still plenty of time left on the Title's effect. No need to rush.

I had seen more than a few people try to save ten minutes and end up leaving this world fifty years early.

[2183] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 meters (0.311 miles); a thousand *li* is about 500 kilometers (311 miles).

[2184] One *zhang* is approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

Whether someone lived or died depended on their will and perseverance. I didn't rush. I let the current carry me along.

Swish.

The brightly colored fish that noticed me seemed to hesitate, then cautiously brushed past.

I was barely moving, so they must not have taken me for a threat.

Good.

If I could fool fish this close to me, that was enough. I suppressed my presence even further and approached the cave.

At the entrance, which was barely wide enough for a grown man to squeeze through, I took a small breath and slipped inside.

Another submerged passage lay hidden beyond it.

No sign of anyone so far.

The passage was as narrow as the entrance and much deeper and longer than I had expected.

I sharpened my senses more than ever and searched for any trace of another presence. Only once I was certain there was none did I begin moving again.

I passed several strange-looking fish and clusters of aquatic plants. I had no idea how far I had gone when a faint light appeared in the distance.

Wait. Light?

This was underwater in Dongting Lake, but it was also a passage running through the inside of a cliff. How could there suddenly be light?

The passage did slope upward, but there was no way its structure could have let light leak in.

Then…

I swam smoothly toward the light, searched my surroundings once more, then shot upward through a small opening in the ceiling of the passage.

Splash!

I sucked in a breath.

Damp air filled my lungs.

At the same time, I felt the transparent gills that had formed around my throat disappear.

The next moment, I climbed out of the water and finally saw the source of the faint light. My eyes widened.

Night-shining pearls.

It was a cave.

A narrow, dark path stretched into the distance. Large and small night-shining pearls had been embedded at regular intervals in the ceiling, which was barely high enough for me to straighten my back.

A submerged passage and a cave carved inside a cliff. Night-shining pearls, too… You'd have to be an idiot not to figure it out by now.

The Lower District Sect's information had been correct. This was unquestionably the Dongting Fisherman's secret refuge.

My heart pounded with the thrill of finally finding him and the tension of the battle to come.

No. Those weren't the only reasons.

What's that?

I followed an unfamiliar smell that pricked my nose and turned my head.

A charred piece of wood lay on the waterlogged cave floor, and oil floated on the pooled water.

A torch? Well, it's not like he has an unlimited supply of night-shining pearls.

The night-shining pearls embedded in the ceiling were obviously low quality, but that did not mean they were cheap.

I had never heard that the Dongting Fisherman was fabulously wealthy, so torches must have been essential for lighting such a long cave.

And that half-burned torch told me something important.

It hasn't been out for long.

A faint warmth still lingered in the wood. It wasn't difficult to deduce that the torch had fallen for some reason no more than one or two *shichen*[2185] ago.

And that pointed to one conclusion.

The Dongting Fisherman is definitely here!

Ultimately, I wasn't looking for a place. I was looking for a man. Finding his secret refuge would mean nothing if the Dongting Fisherman wasn't inside.

But through the torch, the Dongting Fisherman had revealed his presence.

Even if I were in his position, I would never have expected an intruder to enter a secret refuge hidden this well.

That's your mistake.

I rose to my feet and began walking slowly along the path ahead.

I had plenty of excellent equipment—White Flame, my favored weapon, along with the Fire Dragon Armor and the Myriad-Poison Ring—but now wasn't the time to bring any of it out.

It would be better to let my opponent see my empty hands and lower his guard, then exploit the advantage my Inventory gave me.

Drip. Drip-drop.

Listening to the irregular patter of water from the ceiling, I walked on with my presence suppressed as much as possible.

[2185] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

The path had been straight at first, but it soon began to twist and turn, sloping upward in some places and downward in others. I never let down my guard.

But… what are these marks?

It didn't take long for me to realize something was strange.

My sharp eye was part of it, but the passage itself was in an alarming state.

Sections of the walls had been shattered here and there, leaving jagged rocks jutting out. Unlike the rest of the passage, which was covered in green moss, the freshly broken surfaces stood out unmistakably.

Crackle.

The moment I touched one, part of the wall crumbled away.

This couldn't have happened unless someone deliberately used considerable force.

The entire cave was formed from solid rock that had accumulated over at least several hundred years.

Damaging it would require a blow carrying a significant amount of internal energy. But why would the Dongting Fisherman destroy his own precious refuge?

Was there a battle here…? No. This is clearly the work of one person.

I was still far from having the insight to discern the nature and roots of martial arts, but having reached the Supreme Peak realm, I had little trouble inferring what had happened from the traces left throughout the passage.

I furrowed my brow and thought for a moment, then shook my head.

Focus on the Dongting Fisherman first. I can't afford to grow careless or let the tension overwhelm me.

I kept repeating that to myself as I walked.

Then it happened.

Splash! Whoosh!

"…!"

The sudden noise jolted me alert as if someone had dumped cold water over my head.

My fully extended senses analyzed the sound and sent the new information straight to my brain.

Fifty-odd zhang[2186] *ahead. Closer than I expected.*

The sound also echoed with unusual depth and volume. That meant there was a larger space ahead, beyond this narrow cave passage.

Swish.

One step. Then another.

I focused every nerve in my toes as they touched the damp cave floor.

[2186] One *zhang* is approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

It was a blessing that I had used my Scorching Yang Qi beforehand to dry the water that had soaked me through. If water dripping from my body had struck the floor and made a sound, the Dongting Fisherman would have discovered me.

I have to finish this inside the cave. Fighting underwater would make things much harder.

My opponent was a Supreme Peak master of water arts, one of the finest in the world.

I was confident in my own martial prowess, but if I fought the Dongting Fisherman underwater, I would have to bear the full twenty-percent reduction in power the System had warned me about.

Here, however, I had solid ground beneath my feet. This was land, and naturally, the debuff was gone.

I can't let this opportunity slip away.

The fifty-odd *zhang*[2187] between us rapidly dwindled.

Splish. Splaash.

The strange sounds continued, serving as perfect markers of distance and direction. As I approached a bend in the cave passage, I relaxed every muscle in my body.

I was already prepared.

Dozens of possibilities flashed before my eyes—how I would move, how I would end it.

If the Dongting Fisherman proved too formidable, I would use everything I had to kill him. If not, I would capture him and use him to draw out the larger body behind him.

I'll finish it in a single stroke, like a bolt of lightning.

With a short breath, I awakened the fire dragon sleeping deep within my dantian.

The three *jiazi*[2188] of Scorching Yang Qi I had continually replenished through circulation surged into every limb and bone.

Searing heat flooded hundreds of acupoints and the Eight Extraordinary Meridians[2189], driving every physical ability to its limit.

And then…

Pop!

One step was enough.

I planted a foot lightly against the slanted wall and shot forward.

[2187] One *zhang* is approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

[2188] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three *jiazi* represent 180 years.

[2189] The Eight Extraordinary Meridians are channels through which qi flows in traditional Chinese physiology.

[2190] One *zhang* is approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

The passage opened into a chamber some thirty *zhang*[2190] in radius, presumably the heart of the cave.

At its center, a white-haired old man crouched with his back to me.

The Dongting Fisherman!

The silent cry rang through me.

It was hard to believe that this small, shabby old man had harmed so many people. The anger I had buried for a time surged up as a cold flame.

Inventory open. Summon!

As the world slowed, the unknown power of the System covered my entire body as I charged toward the Dongting Fisherman.

Swish. Clack.

Red armor wrapped around my bare upper body.

The Fire Dragon Armor.

Then a cluster of light visible only to me brushed my finger and transformed into the divine artifact known as the Myriad-Poison Ring. At the same time, a spear with a transparent blade appeared in my grasp.

The next moment, three *jiazi*[2191] of Scorching Yang Qi flooded into them all.

Whooooooosh!

The damp air vanished. The river water pooled across the floor vanished. Even the droplets falling from overhead vanished.

No—they evaporated.

Blue-white Force blazed like wildfire across White Flame's transparent spear blade, burning through everything in its path.

And one man stood directly in the path of that searing, destructive concentration of power.

Die.

The arrow had already been loosed. The bird resting in its nest could not escape.

To me, the Dongting Fisherman was no different from that bird.

A bird that had believed its nest was safe.

Even if it realized the truth too late, it could not stop an arrow that had already been fired.

Even if it hurriedly spread its wings, it could not avoid death or injury.

Just like the Dongting Fisherman, who was turning his body very slowly right now.

It's already too late.

But in the next instant, I realized my mistake.

I had been too quick to assume.

Boom!

[2191] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three *jiazi* represent 180 years.

A snow-white streak of light flew in from somewhere and slammed into White Flame’s spear blade.

Chapter 465

Boom!

The impact knocked White Flame's spearhead aside.

The streak of light that had flown in along a bizarre trajectory writhed like a living creature, then rained down over my head.

Shh-shh-shh-shing!

A downpour of Force.

As that destructive power lit the dark cave in an instant, I twisted smoothly out of its path.

Swish. Boom-boom-boom!

My shoulder, neck, waist, chest…

The streak of light swept within a hair's breadth of the vital acupoints throughout my body before piercing and smashing through the solid cave floor.

Had I reacted even a moment later, the attack would have killed me instantly.

But the Dongting Fisherman's attack failed to touch even a single hair on my body, and that moment of danger turned into an opportunity.

Just like now.

Whoom!

White Flame's spearhead, knocked off course by the earlier impact, changed direction sharply in midair and swept toward the Dongting Fisherman's throat.

His grayish-white eyes widened as he turned, and the snow-white streak hurriedly moved to block the spearhead.

But…

That won't be enough.

If the Dongting Fisherman was an old monster who had accumulated enormous internal energy over his long life, then I was a monster who had surpassed those long years through System rewards and countless battles on the edge of death.

Even if our internal energy was equal, my body held the strength of a giant who had surpassed the limits of humanity.

Boom!

The instant the blue-white flames struck the streak of light, a thunderous crash rang out as though the sky itself had split apart, and the Dongting Fisherman was sent flying.

The small old man smashed through solid rock and crashed into the wall. The cave shook, and enormous stalactites came tumbling down.

I glared into the grayish-white eyes visible beyond the falling debris and enunciated every word.

"Get up. Drop the pathetic act."

Crack-crack-crack.

His limbs, limp as a corpse's only moments ago, moved with sudden vigor.

The Dongting Fisherman pulled himself from the hollow his body had left in the wall and cracked his neck from side to side.

Bones ground against one another as he started forward. A long fishing rod had somehow appeared in his wrinkled hand.

The black-wood fishing rod.

It could not compare to Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, but this was the Dongting Fisherman's signature weapon, said to be as strong as meteorite iron and extraordinarily flexible.

Despite being partially damaged, it was still one *zhang*[2192] long. A fishing line and hook with a faint sheen hung from its tip.

That's…

I had never seen it before, but I had heard of it.

Heavenly Silkworm Thread—a rare treasure said to rival the Sichuan Tang Clan's Soul-Severing Thread.

It was strange enough that a mere silkworm cocoon was treated as a spiritual creature, as though the grand name Heavenly Silkworm were not enough. But even that was less astonishing than the thread itself, which was said to be so tough and sharp that not even steel could cut it.

The line attached to the black-wood fishing rod was that very Heavenly Silkworm Thread.

I'll have to be careful.

Caution couldn't hurt. Even if the Fire Dragon Armor was a divine weapon, it wasn't invincible armor capable of blocking everything.

I opened my mouth while staring at the Dongting Fisherman, who had stopped three *zhang*[2193] away.

"You have two choices. First, you die by my hand right here. Second, you tell me everything you know without leaving out a single detail, then atone to your victims. Which will it be?"

"…"

Instead of answering, he stared blankly at me through hazy grayish-white eyes.

There was no emotion in that gaze. A chill ran up my spine as I looked into eyes I could hardly believe belonged to a human being.

…What is this feeling?

Everyone had emotions.

[2192] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three *zhang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); five is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

[2193] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three *zhang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); five is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

But the Dongting Fisherman was different. He was clearly breathing, and I could sense life within him, yet he seemed like an empty object.

What the hell is this…?

I had no time to dwell on it. The next moment, I flinched and tightened my grip on the spear shaft.

A nameless fish had suddenly moved only a few steps away.

Its bones were exposed, and the flesh around its belly had been torn away. It thrashed several times, then went still.

Clear teeth marks scarred its body where someone had bitten into it.

No way.

I narrowed my eyes at the Dongting Fisherman.

Red blood and glinting scales clung to the wrinkles around his mouth.

Only then did I realize what had made the sounds I'd heard on my way here—and what he had been doing until moments ago.

He was ripping into it and eating it raw. While it was still alive.

What kind of lunatic old man was this?

A classic fantasy movie that cable channels used to rerun whenever they had an empty time slot suddenly flashed through my mind.

Now that I looked at him, he did resemble the monster from that movie. The small frame, the hunched back, even the sparse hair.

I clicked my tongue softly and addressed the Dongting Fisherman.

"This changes the genre… The divine artifact you people are looking for isn't a ring,[2194] is it?"

"…"

"Fine, don't answer. I was planning to question you while plucking out the few hairs you have left, one by one."

"Guh."

"Oh, shit. What was that?"

My eyes widened at the Dongting Fisherman's sudden reaction.

I'd just blurted out the first thing that came to mind. Had I actually hit a balding man's sore spot?

But I couldn't tell whether the Dongting Fisherman had reacted to the threat against his hair roots or for some other reason.

Before I could say another word, his old grayish-white eyes bulged, and a tremendous roar burst from his throat.

"GRAAAAAH!"

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

[2194] A reference to Gollum and the One Ring in *The Lord of the Rings*.

This was no shout from the old man who screamed on the hill behind the neighborhood every morning at dawn.

The roar, infused with immense internal energy, traveled through the air and hammered the cavern. Everything around us shook and burst apart—the floor, the walls, everything.

And before the shock wave could even spread, the Dongting Fisherman shot toward me, leaving a pale afterimage behind.

Whooooooosh!

His eyes had turned pitch-black.

As he charged alongside that streak of light, I spoke in a low, heavy voice.

“Turn down the volume, you fucking bastard.”

Fwoosh! Boom!

Blue-white flames enveloped the transparent spearhead as I stepped forward.

Pop!

Three *zhang*[2195] was by no means a short distance.

But the Dongting Fisherman and I were superhumans who had set foot in the realm of Supreme Peak. The moment we shot toward each other, distance lost all meaning. The gap vanished, and the air exploded.

White Flame’s spearhead, carrying unimaginable heat, and the Heavenly Silkworm Thread, writhing like a living creature as it carried several *jiazi*[2196] of internal energy, tore through space.

Shh-shh-shh-shh-shing!

The speed deserved to be called extreme swiftness.

The Heavenly Silkworm Thread extending from the tip of the black-wood fishing rod surged like a wave.

Its bizarre, unfathomable movements were unlike anything I had encountered among the countless weapons I’d faced.

The scars left on the countless corpses scattered throughout Donghu Stronghold flashed before my eyes.

He used this martial art to kill weak, innocent commoners.

I wasn’t especially sensitive, nor was I a *junzi*.[2197] I had no reason to defend the bandits of the Yangtze River Channel League. They were river bandits who had gathered to plunder, and they had undoubtedly taken other people’s lives and property.

[2195] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three *zhang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); five is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

[2196] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[2197] A *junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright person.

It might seem as though I had taken lives too, but the difference between me and them was that they had not killed to survive. They had done it because it served their purposes.

But…

People should never have died like that.

Hundreds had been trampled like ants and cut down like livestock. Hundreds more had been drowned in the middle of Dongting Lake.

And most of them hadn't been martial artists. They were commoners who didn't know so much as a single form of martial arts. There had even been children who couldn't write their own names.

People like that should never have died that way.

No human being should kill another like that.

"You get it, you son of a bitch?"

In the slowed world, my voice vanished beneath the raging wind.

Power flooded the hand gripping the spear shaft. As the mighty Scorching Yang Qi boiled throughout my body, I brought the spearhead down at an angle.

Fwoosh. Shhk!

A single tongue of flame blossomed in the air.

At the same moment, the streak of light scattered.

A section of the Heavenly Silkworm Thread, severed along the path of my spearhead, fluttered away.

The Dongting Fisherman, whose form had been countered so easily, let out a strange scream and swung the black-wood fishing rod again.

Shing. Shh-shh-shh-shh-shing!

Streaks of light split the air in every direction.

The Heavenly Silkworm Thread, filled with Force, sliced through space, piercing and cutting everything in its path.

But I evaded every attack and silently swung my spear.

Shhk! Shhk! Shhk!

I could see it all clearly.

I could tell where that strange fishing-rod weapon would move and how the Heavenly Silkworm Thread attached to it would come for me.

My half-lidded eyes took in every detail, and my wide-open senses read each attack before it came.

If this had been me before my Middle Dantian opened, I would've struggled.

When the place where you stand changes, the scenery you see changes as well.

Opening my Middle Dantian had expanded my senses and granted me a new field of vision I hadn't even known existed. The results were unfolding before my eyes.

Here it comes.

Unusual weapons like the black-wood fishing rod were difficult to master. But once their advantages were fully exploited and paired with the proper martial arts, they became extremely troublesome to face.

Even so, I predicted the oncoming trajectory with perfect accuracy and swung my spear.

Shhk!

"GRAAAAAAAH!"

Another fast, razor-sharp strike severed the Heavenly Silkworm Thread.

The line had once stretched five *zhang*[2198], but I'd reduced it by nearly half without allowing it to inflict any meaningful damage. An even more ferocious aura erupted from the Dongting Fisherman's entire body.

"Now that's more like a person."

But martial arts displayed greater power when the mind and body were stable.

When the mind wavered, the body lost its balance. Movements grew wider and rougher.

And finding a gap in that loosened net wasn't difficult for me.

Whooooooosh!

Flamefire Path.

A single streak of fire raced across the damp cave floor.

Its internal energy consumption was tremendous and its trajectory simple, but like most of the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts, Flamefire Path had two great advantages.

It's fast and destructive.

Boom!

The air grew scorching hot, and every trace of moisture around us evaporated.

I stepped onto the ground, now dry and crumbly as desert sand, and shot forward like an arrow.

Swish!

I turned my head, and the Heavenly Silkworm Thread aimed at the back of my neck swept past.

Having missed, the Dongting Fisherman hurriedly redirected the thread and tried to wrap it around my entire body.

But I kicked off the ground half a beat faster.

Boom! Shhk!

Something as cold as ice traveled through the tip of my foot, then quickly turned hot as fire.

The flesh at the tip of my bare big toe had been sliced clean away.

[2198] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three *zhang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); five is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

The pain was severe enough to make an ordinary person scream, but I accepted it without a flicker.

This is nothing.

I'd endured countless injuries and unimaginable pain while traveling between the modern world and Murim.

There had been times when I writhed in agony as though every bundle of nerves in my body were being severed, times when I had genuinely wanted to die.

Compared to that, an injury like this was nothing.

No—it was an absurdly cheap toll.

In exchange for losing only part of my big toe, I'd gained an opportunity to decide the outcome of this life-and-death duel.

Now!

My hands and feet obeyed the command from my brain, moving like flowing water.

Faster and cleaner than ever, without the slightest wasted motion.

I drew back the spear shaft, then hurled it forward with all my strength.

Whooooooosh—thud!

A strike like a flash of lightning.

White Flame left my hand, smashed through the Dongting Fisherman's shoulder as he sensed the danger and tried to retreat, then buried itself deep in the wall.

"GRAAAAAAAH!"

As his scream of pain filled the cave, I raised my fist toward him.

"I told you to turn down the volume."

"…!"

Thud!

Chapter 466

Even without using internal energy—and though I'd held back—I had already far surpassed human limits through pure physical strength alone.

Boom!

My fist struck him square in the face, and the Dongting Fisherman's entire body jerked. To him, it must have felt like being hit with an iron club.

His pitch-black pupils trembled. Blood-soaked yellow teeth tumbled from his gaping mouth.

One more.

Thud!

The Dongting Fisherman, blood pouring from his mouth and nose like a waterfall, staggered and waved his hand.

It was only a small movement, but my sharpened senses took in everything happening around me with perfect clarity.

Swish!

Something sliced faintly but sharply through the air, aiming for my back.

I already knew what it was.

The Heavenly Silkworm Thread.

Instead of dodging, I twisted the wrist of the hand gripping the Dongting Fisherman's black-wood fishing rod.

Crack!

His bones broke. The black-wood fishing rod slipped from his powerless grasp, and the Force-infused Heavenly Silkworm Thread fluttered limply through the air.

"What the fuck are you trying to pull, you son of a bitch? Who do you take me for, a sucker?"

The answer that came back was a heavy sound splitting the air.

Whoom!

The Dongting Fisherman's palm strike shot toward me with terrifying momentum. But I was already prepared. Without hesitation, I thrust out my own palm to meet it.

Boom!

The swift, concise first form of the Flame Divine Palm.

Two Forces—one white, one blue—collided in midair, sending razor-sharp winds whipping around us.

Through my wildly tossing hair, I stared coldly at the Dongting Fisherman.

"What are you doing, you bald bastard?"

"…!"

I didn't need an answer.

I already knew what I had to do, and the tip of my foot was already lashing out at the Dongting Fisherman's knee with lightning speed.

Thud!

His bones crunched. His body staggered, and blood spilled from the corner of his mouth.

The heavy impact momentarily disrupted the flow of his internal energy, and the Palm Force gathered in the palm still pressed against mine began to fade.

"All right. As of today, we're officially a thing."

The scales had already tipped in my favor. I laced my fingers tightly through his, then twisted with all my strength.

Crack!

Sibu-leol.[2199] I'd never even held a woman's hand in my life, yet here in Murim, I'd interlocked fingers with enough men to fill a truck.

Of course, an affectionate finger-lock fueled by the pent-up rage of a man who'd been single all his life never failed to deliver.

Just like now.

"Gyaaaaaaah!"

A scream of agony finally burst from the Dongting Fisherman's mouth.

I clenched my fist and punched him again and again as he stared at me with his pitch-black eyes wide open.

Thud! Thud! Thud-thud-thud!

Under the unceasing rain of fists and palms, the Dongting Fisherman's movements slowly weakened.

Or so I thought.

"Gueeeeeegh!"

What was it?

Had I let my guard down because I thought victory was assured? Had I grown too confident that I could capture him alive?

Whatever the reason, I hadn't been thorough.

And that created an opening.

Splaaash!

My vision turned completely red.

The sticky blood the Dongting Fisherman vomited drenched my face and froze my body for an instant.

And the counterattack of a Supreme Peak master fighting for his life was fiercer than I'd expected.

[2199] *Sibu-leol* is a colloquial Korean curse, roughly equivalent to "fuck."

Boom!

With a sound like compressed air exploding, a stream of internal energy seemed to pass straight through the surface of the Fire Dragon Armor and slammed into my upper body.

My vision blurred.

As the scenery flashed past, a thought crossed my mind.

Damn it. Inner-Family Heavy Hand.

He still had this much strength left?

I swallowed the blood surging up my throat and drew on my internal energy.

I'd taken an unexpected blow, but compared to the Dongting Fisherman's condition, this was nothing.

That I had suffered only a minor internal injury despite being caught off guard by the Inner-Family Heavy Hand was proof enough.

Whoooosh!

I sent the flow of internal energy, interrupted for only an instant, coursing through every limb and acupoint in my body.

The acupoints damaged by the Inner-Family Heavy Hand throbbed slightly, but that was all.

A carp didn't die just because someone scooped a bowlful of water from its pond.

Neither would I.

I'll finish this.

I twisted around in midair while hurtling backward. The opposite wall of the cave rushed toward me. I planted my foot against it lightly, then detonated the internal energy flowing through my toes.

Boom!

With a roar like the sky splitting apart, the unyielding rocks in the wall exploded.

Hundreds—thousands—of fragments tore through the air in every direction, but I was already gone.

Whooooooosh!

Heavier than a rock, faster than the wind.

My entire body cleaved through the air several times faster than when I'd been thrown back, carrying the weight of ten thousand *geun*.[2200]

"Dongting Fisherman!"

My shout shook the vast cavern. Several *jiazi*[2201] of Scorching Yang Qi carried in my voice pressed down the water and pushed the rocks aside.

And at the end of it all stood one man.

[2200] *Geun* is a Korean unit of weight: one *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

[2201] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here to measure accumulated internal energy.

"…!"

The Dongting Fisherman had just pulled White Flame from his shoulder and the rock wall behind him when he spotted me. His eyes flew wide.

His blackened pupils trembled, flashing a sliver of white.

His mouth quivered open, and his one remaining front tooth trembled pitifully.

"D-d-d-don't…"

Don't come any closer?

Fuck off.

I had no idea why the man who'd been acting like a lunatic only moments ago was suddenly trembling like that, but my mind was already made up.

I was going to bring you back in one piece if possible… but that's not happening now.

It was too late for regret. The Dongting Fisherman should have regretted his actions long ago.

Before joining hands with Dark Heaven. Before brutally slaughtering innocent commoners and children.

That was when he should have regretted his actions and repented.

Now that we'd come this far, there was no need for repentance.

All that remained was punishment for his crimes.

You're fucking dead.

I didn't care if I crushed all four of his limbs. As long as he kept breathing, I could tear out every last strand of hair and every tooth, then drive a stalactite up his ass.

I would take his life only after he'd spat out everything he knew about Dark Heaven.

I'd leave him just alive enough to breathe.

Only until my anger at what he had done had diminished, even slightly.

With exactly that much force behind me, I shot toward him and extended my fist through the slowed world.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Whoooooosh!

Fiercely blazing blue-white hellfire swallowed the palm strike the Dongting Fisherman thrust out with his broken hand.

His Palm Force, now as murky as muddy water, shattered and evaporated beneath the Scorching Yang Qi. Beyond the ceaseless whirlwind and flashes of light, my flame-wreathed fist smashed through the Body-Protecting Qi surrounding him.

Crack! Booooom!

Every blood vessel in the Dongting Fisherman's bulging eyes burst. He vomited blood as he was driven into the wall.

Fine, spiderweb-like cracks spread across the hard rock of the cavern wall. Soon, they widened into a massive fissure that reached all the way to the ceiling.

Rumble. Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The ceiling collapsed, and the ground split apart.

The rocks that had endured tremendous water pressure deep beneath the vast freshwater lake of Dongting Lake began collapsing one after another. Streams of water surged up from every direction.

Collapse.

This space, created at some unknown point in the past, would soon come crashing down.

Just like its owner, who would never return to his secret refuge.

I have to hurry.

Rattle-rattle!

I pressed the Dongting Fisherman's acupoints to stop the bleeding. Then, in case anything happened, I sealed him with Pressure-Point Strikes so he could not move even a hair.

I hoisted the small old man onto my back, then punched forward without hesitation.

Boom! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A raging current was visible through the sinkhole-like opening in the floor.

I took a deep breath and leaped into the violent water.

Splash!

Cold water closed around my body, and a familiar message rang in my ears.

SYSTEM

Title effect activated: Water Rescue Worker
Special Skill embedded in the Title applied.
Water Rescue Worker's Webbed Feet generated.
Water Rescue Worker's Gills generated.
Remaining duration: 18 hours, 43 minutes, 32 seconds

I had plenty of time.

I moved my body powerfully with the current.

Before long, I noticed the Dongting Fisherman constantly blowing bubbles from his mouth and nose. The sight reminded me of something I'd momentarily overlooked.

What the… Ah.

Even a master of water arts needed enough internal energy and awareness to use those techniques.

He didn't breathe through gills like I did. If he remained underwater too long, he might die.

Wait. If that's the case…

A flash of insight struck me.

At the same time, I began swimming with all my strength.

Interlocking fingers was one thing, but I wasn't about to give up my first kiss too.

Especially not to a crazy old man who was nearly a hundred!

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A vibration that began somewhere deep underwater grew so powerful that it reached the people on the surface.

At the sudden anomaly, the old boatman shrank into himself with fear in his eyes, while the other three men's faces stiffened.

"Um, I think…"

"It seems it's finally begun. Or perhaps it has already ended."

Gung Gibang answered Cheongpung's murmur in a grave voice.

Hyuk Mujin, who had been anxiously watching the trembling cliff and river, abruptly spoke.

"We have to go."

Gung Gibang furrowed his brow.

"What?"

"It's certain that something happened to our Captain. I have a bad feeling."

"But Jin Taekyung, that bastard…"

"He told us not to move and to wait here. I know."

"Then why?"

"I've always been terrible at listening to people."

"Damn. You sound proud of it."

"Isn't it better than sitting here sucking our fingers?"

At Hyuk Mujin's words, Gung Gibang gnawed at his lower lip.

He, too, had been uneasy for some time.

He didn't know exactly when it had begun, but his heart was pounding violently, and every one of his senses was on edge.

What's wrong with me? Did something really happen to that bastard?

A face flashed before his eyes.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

No—the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

The kind of bastard who looked capable of crawling back alive even if he were

thrown into the deepest pit of the underworld. More vicious than A-Gwi[2202] and strong enough to beat Yama[2203] himself into the ground.

I've never once imagined that bastard dying… But nothing is absolute. Surely not?

Gung Gibang hadn't dismissed what Jin Taekyung had said before entering the river. After traveling with him for so long, he knew there was always a reason behind the man's words and actions.

But this time, he couldn't help wavering.

Goddammit. The weather's gone completely to shit too. What the hell am I supposed to do?

Rumble. Crash!

Just as the old boatman had warned a couple of *shichen*[2204] earlier, even calling the current weather on Dongting Lake the worst imaginable would have been an understatement.

A raging storm. Lightning crashing down from the sky.

Gung Gibang looked around with conflicted eyes and finally opened his mouth.

Or rather, he was just about to when—

"It's all right."

"Huh?"

"What?"

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin turned their heads at the same time.

Someone was smiling brightly in their field of view.

At the edge of the small island where they stood, Cheongpung had been lying facedown, listening to something. He brushed the sand from his ear and grinned.

"Benefactor is coming."

And then—

Splaaash!

A figure shot from the water atop a towering spray and landed heavily on the sandy shore.

A muscular young man with a small old man slung over his back.

It was Jin Taekyung.

"Captain!"

"You're back!"

"Benefactooor!"

"Stay back, you dickheads. If any of you tries to hug me, all three of you are getting murdered today."

[2202] A-Gwi is a legendary Dogon from Sichuan, invoked here as a measure of ferocity.

[2203] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld.

[2204] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; a couple of *shichen* is about four hours.

After stopping the three men charging toward him with cries of joy, Jin Taekyung continued in a grave voice.

“We don’t have time, so I’ll get straight to the point. Raise your hand if you’ve ever kissed someone. Or if you want to try it. Hands up.”

Two of them caught on quickly.

One was hopelessly oblivious.

As Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin quietly backed away, one hand shot into the air amid a bright, innocent shout.

“Me! Me! I’ve never kissed anyone before!”

“Fuck. Thank God.”

“Huh?”

Beaming from ear to ear, Jin Taekyung held the Dongting Fisherman out toward the bewildered Cheongpung.

“Your wish just came true.”

Rumble. Crash!

Thunder and lightning shook the entire world.

Chapter 467

I've always been the kind of person who thinks the process matters just as much as the result.

But sometimes, I deliberately look away from the process.

Not every process has to be perfect and beautiful, after all.

What matters is the result. The result.

Yeah, that's all I'm saying.

And behind the process that everyone—including me—had chosen to ignore, an excellent result finally revealed itself.

Cough! Splash!

Water spilled between the Dongting Fisherman's cracked lips as he coughed.

Cheongpung, who had shown a moving spirit of self-sacrifice against the Dongting Fisherman, opened his mouth with a strange expression.

"It feels weird."

I exchanged glances with Hyuk Mujin, Gung Gibang, and the old boatman, then answered solemnly.

"It's always like that the first time."

"Did you feel the same way, Benefactor?"

"…Of course."

I'd never done it before, but even if I did, I wouldn't feel the way Cheongpung did. No, I shouldn't.

I subtly averted my eyes as I answered. Cheongpung nodded, then took a deep breath.

"But I really don't understand this."

"You're excited. That's all."

"It smelled strange, too. Like fish."

What a nose.

I remembered the Dongting Fisherman tearing into a raw fish before our fight and answered.

"You're imagining it."

"My stomach feels sick."

"That's because your body is releasing hormones. Kissing is good for your immune system and helps relieve stress too…"

"What?"

"Nothing."

"My stomach just feels really nauseous. I want some sweets."

Hyuk Mujin patted Cheongpung's shoulder guiltily.

“I’ll buy you some later, Young Hero Cheong.”

“You will, Hyuk Mujin?”

“Yes. I’ll find some way to feed you until your stomach bursts.”

“But you’re poor too, Hyuk Mujin. Last time, I saw you picking up silver nyang[2205] at the ferry landing…”

“My father is rich.”

Hyuk Mujin only seemed poor because following me around had put him through all sorts of hardship. His family business was thriving more by the day, so he was still the son of a wealthy household.

At the proud declaration of a second-generation rich kid planning to bleed his father dry, the other two men, who had been watching Cheongpung with sad eyes, joined in.

“Cheongpung, I’ll contribute too, even if I have to beg for the money.”

“This old man is willing to lower your fare a little as well.”

“Wow! Really?”

“…”

A pang of guilt stabbed at my heart.

But it couldn’t be helped. It had definitely been his choice.

After doing my best to justify myself, I checked the Dongting Fisherman’s condition.

“How is he?”

At Hyuk Mujin’s question from over my shoulder, I nodded.

“He’s fine.”

“Uh… He doesn’t look particularly fine.”

I was momentarily speechless as I looked down at the Dongting Fisherman.

Both arms were twisted at bizarre angles, and countless wounds showed through his clothes, which had been torn to shreds.

Those were merely the injuries visible to the naked eye. The severe internal injuries were a bonus.

“What on earth happened?”

I gave them a brief summary of what had happened inside the underwater cave.

“I was on guard in case anything happened, but he was weaker than I expected, so I beat the shit out of him and dragged him back.”

“…”

After a brief silence, Hyuk Mujin spoke.

“But the Dongting Fisherman is a master of incredible water arts.”

“That’s why I beat him on land. Turns out there was a cave in there.”

[2205] A nyang was a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to money measured in silver.

"You have an incredible talent for making extremely difficult things sound easy."

"It wasn't extremely easy, but it wasn't extremely difficult either."

"…"

"The important thing is that he's still breathing."

"The fact that he's still breathing looks like a miracle."

"Considering what that old man has done, he deserves to die right now."

"That's true. Either way, it's fortunate. I was worried about the Dongting Fisherman, of course, but I was also worried that Dark Heaven's other bastards might be there with him."

That was something I had considered as well.

According to Honglan's testimony, the Dongting Fisherman had been the sole culprit behind the tragedy on Dongting Lake.

But slaughtering Yangtze One Saber and so many others at Donghu Stronghold would have required at least two Supreme Peak masters, if not more.

Mungyeong said the same thing.

No matter how rapidly I had grown, taking on two or more Supreme Peak masters at once was… hard to say.

Even among people who had reached the same realm, ability varied wildly.

The Dongting Fisherman was a step below me.

I'd been lucky. If the Dongting Fisherman had been working with another of Dark Heaven's powerhouses, I might have been the one to go down instead.

Of course, I wouldn't have started a fight with such slim odds in the first place.

"But shouldn't this old man be waking up by now? Why isn't he moving at all? Did he swallow too much water?"

At Gung Gibang's question, Cheongpung, who was rinsing his mouth with lake water, answered.

"He's been hit with Pressure-Point Strikes. Right, Benefactor?"

"Yeah. Exactly."

At present, the Dongting Fisherman's Paralysis, Mute, and Sleep Acupoints had all been struck.

Even if the seal on his Sleep Acupoint wore off and he woke from his forced sleep, his body would remain paralyzed, and he wouldn't be able to move his lips. Forget resisting—he couldn't even squirm like a grub.

"What do you intend to do now?"

"We've accomplished our objective, so we're going back."

We were not the only ones who knew the location of this place. If Dark Heaven had caught wind of it and sent reinforcements, we could easily have ended up trapped instead.

If a monster like the Western Heaven Demon Lord showed up, we might have to prepare ourselves to die.

There were clear limits to what Cheongpung and I could do alone.

Dark Heaven was unquestionably involved in the string of incidents across Hubei Province. The biggest problem was that we knew neither where they were nor who their members were.

But if we could force the Dongting Fisherman to talk, we could uncover every last detail about them and launch a counterattack.

The Fire King and the Slaughter Saint—two peerless Supreme Peak masters—would commit their full strength, as would Wudang and the Zhuge Clan, the undisputed rulers of Hubei Province.

"We're leaving. Right now."

But an obstacle I hadn't considered stood in our way.

"Um, Great Hero."

The old boatman had suddenly spoken. After hesitating for a moment, he continued, his face stiff.

"I beg your pardon, but in this old man's humble opinion, it simply can't be done."

"What?"

"As you know, Great Hero, Dongting Lake right now…"

Rumble-rumble-rumble! Crash!

Thunder booming from all directions swallowed the rest of the boatman's words.

He hunched his shoulders as though frightened, then pointed around us with anxious eyes.

"Look. How can we possibly launch a boat in conditions like these?"

"…!"

He had good reason to be trembling.

The sky had turned pitch-black, and lightning struck at irregular intervals. Heavy rain had begun pouring down at some point, noticeably swelling the waters of Dongting Lake. Violent whirlpools battered the cliffs and rocks.

Of all times for this to happen.

It hadn't been this bad when we entered the Dongting Fisherman's secret refuge. Yet in less than a single shichen,[2206] the situation around us had rapidly deteriorated toward the worst possible outcome.

But…

"We have to go."

"G-Great Hero."

[2206] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"I understand that you're afraid, but it's possible. You saw with your own eyes how we got here."

I had suffered a minor internal injury, but I was still in good shape.

On top of that, we had Cheongpung, a Supreme Peak master, and Gung Gibang, who possessed exceptional martial arts. Hyuk Mujin could also lend a hand in an emergency.

No matter how bad the weather or how violent the current, it wasn't enough to declare the journey impossible.

The old boatman thought differently.

"I've held an oar on Dongting Lake for more than forty years. Today was the first time I've ever ferried great masters like you, but it was also the first time I've ever launched a boat in weather this vicious."

The old boatman struggled to get the words out, his voice trembling.

"All I know how to do is read the water and row a boat. I'm an unremarkable old man, but I've spent more than half my life on Dongting Lake. If it can't be done, it can't be done."

"Boatman."

Gung Gibang stepped forward, but before he could say anything, the boatman shook his head repeatedly.

"I know what you're going to say. But no matter how skilled you are, it's clear you won't make it very far."

"Why do you think that?"

"The boat won't hold up."

"…!"

At the boatman's firm declaration, everyone—including me—stared with wide eyes.

He was right. No matter how sturdy it was, a ferryboat was still a ferryboat.

To find the Dongting Fisherman's secret refuge, the boat had needed to be light and small. It had been perfect for that purpose, but those same advantages were now its greatest weaknesses.

Even by the shortest route, it'll take at least two shichen[2207] to reach land… What if the boat sinks before then?

The answer to my own question came back immediately.

No.

Even if I used my internal energy to perform Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water,[2208] the distance left is too great. And that was before the weather became like this. The boatman is right. The boat won't hold.

[2207] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2208] Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water is a martial-arts movement feat for crossing the surface of water.

Even at a glance, I could see patches where wood had been torn from the surface of the ferryboat pulled up onshore.

Like its white-haired owner, the ferryboat was showing its age, and today's currents and voyage had been especially rough.

Damn it.

This wasn't something I could solve by persuading the boatman.

I could use the Water Rescue Worker Title's effect, which still had plenty of time remaining, or try the same method of using the Inventory that I had used at Dongting Lake before.

But no matter how I considered the situation, the risk was too great.

"Captain."

At Hyuk Mujin's voice, I raised my head and saw everyone looking at me.

Under their gazes, I thought for a moment, then bit my lip.

"What about the route leading in?"

"Pardon?"

I spoke clearly to the old boatman, who had hunched his shoulders at another peal of thunder.

"If it's difficult to get out, wouldn't it also be difficult to get in? Especially in conditions like these."

"Ah, of course it would. The passage is so narrow that nothing but a ferryboat like mine could enter, and with these insane currents, getting in would be several times harder than getting out. Launching a boat on Dongting Lake in weather like this is madness to begin with."

Then that was even better.

It meant the weather would naturally prevent any possible incursion by Dark Heaven as well.

We should wait here until the weather settles down.

I had just finished that thought and was about to give the order when—

Jerk. Jerk-jerk-jerk!

Someone nearby suddenly began to move.

I and the others turned our heads toward its source and opened our eyes wide at the same time.

What the hell?

The small old man who had been lying motionless as though dead—the Dongting Fisherman—was twitching.

Even as we watched, the trembling running through his body grew faster and stronger.

"He was definitely under Pressure-Point Strikes… How?"

Cheongpung muttered the words like a groan.

As the person who had struck the Dongting Fisherman's pressure points, I could not easily accept what was happening either.

But my surprise lasted only a moment.

Before my mind could fully process the situation, my body was already moving.

Swish!

I shot forward like a gust of wind and thrust out my hand at top speed.

First, the Sleep Acupoint.

Next, the Paralysis Acupoint.

Finally, the Mute Acupoint.

The instant I finished striking his pressure points again, I realized something I hadn't expected.

His acupoint seals had never come undone in the first place. This was simply… the Dongting Fisherman's body reacting independently of his will.

I faltered in confusion.

Grab!

A hand seized my wrist, which had been left hanging in midair.

The Dongting Fisherman was staring at me, his eyes wide open.

Unlike in the cave, his pupils looked like those of an ordinary person.

They were filled with fear.

And then a hollow voice, empty as though his soul had left his body, pierced my ears.

"Run."

What?

I had no time to form a question.

I wasn't given a chance to react.

The moment every sense in my body went taut, an enormous roar erupted behind me.

Kaboom—!

Chapter 468

Rumble-rumble-rumble, crash!

It was a storm unlike anything anyone had ever experienced.

Every time thunder boomed alongside the lightning, the rain grew heavier, and the river thrashed like a violent dragon.

And one ship was trying to fight its way against it all.

“Hard to port!”

The ship rocked like a willow leaf amid the raging waves. At Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song’s shout from the stern, the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold gritted their teeth.

“Grrrrgh!”

“Keep rowing! Put your asses into it and row!”

“Anyone who slacks off from this moment on had better watch out! What was it called again? Right! I’ll sentence you to the dip-and-taste punishment![2209]”

“Aaaaaah!”

Every one of them was a seasoned, highly skilled sailor.

But despite Mu Song’s experienced commands and the river bandits’ efforts to summon every last ounce of strength, the worst weather they had ever encountered refused to let the ship advance any farther.

Crash! Boom!

The sail, swollen almost to the point of tearing, was driven back by the force of the wind. Rocks large and small flew in from every direction and slammed into the deck.

Disbelief flashed through Mu Song’s eyes at the impossible sight.

What in the world is this?

Martial arts were not the only thing he had learned from his Master, the Seafaring King.

If anything, he had first learned how to steer all sorts of ships, predict the weather, and read the currents—before he had learned martial arts.

Mu Song had been a sailor before he was a Murim martial artist, and no river bandit would follow an incompetent captain.

The little boy who had once yearned for the Yangtze had grown into a captain skilled enough to earn the respect of even old sailors. Even his coldhearted Master, who had not shown his Disciple the slightest hint of affection, had once said:

[2209] “Dip-and-taste” refers to dipping food into sauce before eating; Mu Song turns the phrase into the name of a joking punishment.

> "It's a shame. If your grit and martial talent had been even half as good as your skill with ships, you might have taken your Senior Brother's place."

There could not be two masters of the Yangtze River Channel League.

The Seafaring King had already chosen his Senior Disciple as his successor, so he sent Mu Song to Sichuan. After founding Water Dragon Stronghold, Mu Song soon distinguished himself and seized control of Sichuan's stretch of the Yangtze at a young age.

Yet even Mu Song had never seen anything like this.

His Master, the Seafaring King, and the old river bandits who had spent their entire lives as sailors before retiring had probably never seen it either.

It wasn't like this when we left the Yangtze tributary. So how…?

The reason was simple.

The weather had changed with shocking speed.

And they were currently on none other than Dongting Lake.

After receiving Zhuge Feng's sudden summons, Mu Song had selected his most capable subordinates, crossed Tianling Falls, and immediately headed for Dongting Lake after asking around for Jin Taekyung's whereabouts.

Not long afterward, they had run into a storm more suited to the middle of the sea.

Is this even possible? On Dongting Lake?

Hubei Province's climate was generally warm. Its annual rainfall was fairly consistent, and although the Yangtze occasionally flooded, the flooding was rarely severe. In fact, it was one of the reasons the region had become such a fertile breadbasket.

Dongting Lake? It was certainly one of the three largest lakes under heaven, but it was still only a lake.

No matter how bad the weather became, it should not have been worse than the Yangtze's currents. Compared to the unpredictable whirlpools of the sea, it should have been laughable.

That was what he had believed.

At least until two *shichen*[2210] ago.

It wasn't this bad when we first launched the ship.

He had not been particularly worried. Since Dongting Lake was not connected to the Yangtze or the sea routes, there was no way to bring a swift ship here. They had borrowed a small merchant vessel instead and headed for the place where Jin Taekyung's group was said to have gone.

Or rather, they had tried to.

[2210] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours. Two *shichen* are approximately four hours.

Unlike at the beginning, the weather had grown steadily worse the closer they came to their destination.

It was as though they had crossed some invisible line. Strange phenomena that should not have been possible on a lake were appearing everywhere.

Whooooooosh.

A waterspout rose with a chilling howl of wind.

It towered to a dizzying height, blocking the narrow waterway as it advanced toward the merchant vessel. A groan slipped between Mu Song's clenched teeth.

"What the fucking hell is this…?"

If they were caught in that, it was over. Even if they managed to get past the waterspout, a merchant vessel this flimsy would not survive for long.

Torn between concern for his subordinates' safety and his desire for revenge against Dark Heaven, which had killed Yangtze One Saber, Mu Song finally spoke.

"I'm sorry, but I'm afraid this is as far as we can go."

An old voice answered him.

"That's enough."

And then—

Swish!

Behind Mu Song, a small figure that had remained perfectly balanced leaped from the mast.

He shot toward the waterspout through the driving rain and wind, then clenched his fist.

Hoooooong.

A single stream of wind wrapped around the fist mottled with age spots. The air stopped moving, and not a single drop of rain dared approach.

At the tip of that fist, hellfire capable of burning everything took shape.

"Get the hell out of my way."

With a voice like boiling lava, Fire King Jeok Cheongang threw a punch.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Whooooooosh!

The next moment, Mu Song and the river bandits saw it clearly.

The flames rising from the fist transformed into a fire dragon and bit into the waist of the waterspout.

The churning water collapsed in an instant beneath the overwhelming Scorching Yang Qi, every trace of moisture evaporating. The waterspout, which had been bearing down on the merchant vessel with the force of ten thousand *geun*[2211], became a dense cloud of steam that spread around them like fog.

[2211] A Korean *geun* is approximately 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* are approximately 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

Then—

Boom!

The heavy sound of something splitting the air scattered the steam.

Jeok Cheongang stood tall in midair, looking down at the merchant vessel. His voice, more deeply subdued than usual, drifted from his lips.

“What are you waiting for? Hurry up and follow me.”

He was not speaking to Mu Song or the river bandits under his command. Their roles had been decided from the beginning, and they had more than fulfilled them.

Only true masters belonged on the battlefield ahead.

And as everyone watched, one person stepped forward.

“Single Reed Crossing the River. Even Master Bodhidharma of Shaolin used a reed leaf to cross a river. From now on, you’d better come down instead of wasting your internal energy for no reason.”

Not a trace of emotion could be found in the flat, dry voice.

The bright, warm boy who had been caring for the sick as a medical apprentice only a short while ago was nowhere to be found.

As Mu Song and the river bandits flinched and moved aside, Mungyeong clicked his tongue inwardly.

Dong Feng. You foolish Disciple. In the end, things turned out exactly as you wanted.

He had lived as a medical apprentice for more than forty years.

With hands that had taken more than a thousand lives, he had treated and cared for the sick.

Instead of fiends, he had hunted the bastard called plague. He had gained the undeserved reputation of being a Divine Physician, but he had never once accepted wealth or sought fame.

It had merely been atonement.

And a vow.

But now, the stone pagoda he had built deep within his heart over decades of living as a medical apprentice had come crashing down.

No—perhaps it had collapsed the day he boarded the swift ship leaving Sichuan.

This too is the path this old man chose. How could I blame anyone else?

With a dry chuckle, he stepped forward. Behind him appeared a middle-aged man in disheveled scholar’s robes.

“This junior will go with you, Seniors.”

At the words of Zhuge Feng, the current Family Head of the Zhuge Clan and the Crouching Dragon Guest, Mungyeong answered in a dry voice.

“Of course you should. Why else would I bring a burden like you?”

“You certainly have a talent for embarrassing people.”

Mungyeong made a show of frowning. He had no intention of listening to Zhuge Feng ramble, especially when the man was no more than a babe compared to him.

“Enough nonsense. Get on my back.”

“You underestimate this junior. My enlightenment may not match that of the other Family Heads of the Five Great Families, but when it comes to internal energy alone…”

“There’s a reason I brought you here. If I had prioritized martial arts, I would have brought that youngster Hyeongong of Wudang instead. But shouldn’t someone remain back there?”

“…!”

Perfected Being Hyeongong was a master whose seniority placed him alongside the Sect Leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

Mu Song and the river bandits had been unable to determine Mungyeong’s identity beyond knowing that he was a Returned to Youth master. They were shocked to hear him refer to Perfected Being Hyeongong, a respected elder throughout Murim, as a child.

“Gasp!”

“Who in the world is that man…?”

But Mungyeong had neither the time nor the inclination to answer.

He extended a hand, and Zhuge Feng’s body came sliding toward him.

After seizing none other than the current Family Head of the Zhuge Clan with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space, Mungyeong lightly pushed off the deck and soared like a bird.

Swish!

A movement technique both stealthy and impossibly elusive.

Not a single person left aboard the ship could recognize the Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step at its pinnacle.

Leaving the stunned men behind, Mungyeong’s body shot forward as though folding space.

“Is this the right direction?”

Splash!

Two—no, three figures sped forward, their feet stepping across the water.

Zhuge Feng, dangling from Mungyeong’s hand, answered Jeok Cheongang.

“According to what Ship-Fire Boy told us, we only need to keep heading straight from here.”

“Are you certain?”

“Of course. However…”

“However?”

After hesitating for a moment, Zhuge Feng continued.

"We still don't know whether Jin Taekyung is there."

"He is. Without a doubt."

Jeok Cheongang immediately shook his head. His tone was nearly one of certainty.

"This weather… It isn't a coincidence. Something unknown came here, and Taekyung is clearly after it."

"It's too early to jump to conclusions. We must first identify what it is."

At Mungyeong's words, Jeok Cheongang unconsciously reached inside his robes.

His hand closed around something as sharp as a sword blade and as hard as armor.

When Mungyeong had first brought it and shown it to the two of them, neither Jeok Cheongang nor Zhuge Feng had been able to believe what it was.

What is this? What in the world is happening?

The unease in the old man's chest swelled rapidly, and his speed increased with it as he crossed the water using Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A tremendous roar rang out from beyond the violent rain and dense fog.

All three men's eyes widened.

"This is…"

It was not thunder and lightning rumbling across the sky.

The black heavens above them were silent. The enormous sound had clearly come from somewhere several hundred *jang*[2212] ahead.

"You bastards—!"

Jeok Cheongang's furious roar rang out as he shot forward first. Mungyeong followed close behind, holding Zhuge Feng firmly in his grasp as the water split to either side.

But before even an instant had passed, the three men were forced to stop simultaneously.

"…!"

The shock was so immense that none of them could speak.

They did not even need to move closer to confirm what had caused it.

At last, the identity of "it" appeared in the distance.

The three men stood frozen, utterly speechless.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The cliff collapsed with a deafening roar.

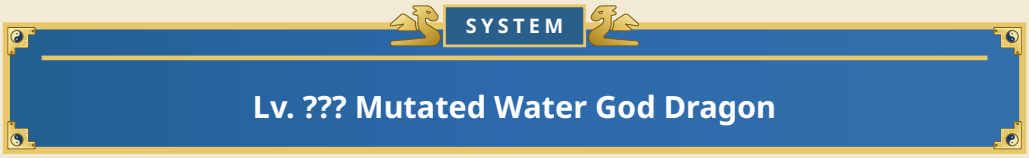
[2212] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Boulders weighing ten thousand *geun*[2213], which had clearly been part of it for centuries, came pouring down like a rain shower, and an enormous spray of water surged upward.

But none of that mattered.

I stared with trembling eyes at “it” rising amid the destruction.

More precisely, I stared at the System window floating above its head.



[2213] A Korean *geun* is approximately 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* are approximately 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

Chapter 469

Everyone saw it. They could see it.

Amid the blackened sky and the violent wind and rain, a shower of strangely shaped rocks came crashing down.

Rumble-rumble-rumble, crash!

When a massive boulder struck the lake, spray erupted several *jang*[2214] into the air. Birds that had lost their nests tumbled from the collapsing cliff with shrill cries, while torrential rain and lightning battered the world without pause.

And as everything collapsed around them… one being alone reared up.

Whooooooosh!

Water cascaded down its body like a waterfall.

Far below, the humans reduced to tiny dots gazed up at the being that had finally revealed itself, their eyes filled with stunned disbelief.

It was enormous.

Even that word felt inadequate, yet no other came to mind.

Only one question filled everyone's thoughts.

What is that?

Scales gleamed with an ominously beautiful black sheen. Its body was so thick that ten burly men with their arms outstretched could barely have encircled it.

Their gazes traveled up the long, sinuous body, more than thirty *jang*[2215] of it visible above the surface, until they reached two horns jutting from its forehead.

And beneath them, its eyes.

Blood-red pupils stretched into long vertical slits. As the scales around its mouth slowly parted, they revealed saw-edged teeth and a maw like a dark cavern.

Grrrrr.

The vicious growl echoing down from far above sent a chill deep into the bones of Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng.

What in the world…?

Zhuge Feng had been called the greatest genius in his clan since infancy.

He possessed an extraordinary mind that never forgot anything he had seen, along with an insatiable thirst for knowledge. Over the years, he had devoured tens of thousands of books and made the vast knowledge of the world his own.

The river of knowledge within Zhuge Feng was endlessly broad and deep.

Or so he had thought.

Until he saw that.

[2214] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Several *jang* means several times that distance.

[2215] Thirty *jang* is about 91 meters (298 ft).

This cannot be.

For the first time in his life, he felt the fear of confronting the unknown.

At that moment, Zhuge Feng realized that all the knowledge and information he had accumulated had turned to foam.

He also realized that fragments of the countless myths and legends he had dismissed as nonsense now stood before his eyes.

Could those absurd stories… truly have been real?

Zhuge Feng had always placed absolute faith in the power of knowledge.

He was a martial artist, but first and foremost, he was the Family Head of the distinguished Zhuge Clan, and he had used reliable information and knowledge to protect his many clansmen and his family's power.

To a man like him, unverified superstition was not even worth considering. Believing in an illusion no one had ever seen was simply foolish.

But someone a hundred *jang*[2216] away from Zhuge Feng was different.

Unlike Zhuge Feng, he was not a Family Head responsible for an entire household. He was merely an old boatman who had survived by relying on his own experience and a single ferryboat.

"…!"

The old boatman stared into the sky with trembling eyes.

A colossal being stood tall amid the collapse of everything around it. The sight alone made his legs buckle, while unbearable awe and fear pressed down on his shabby shoulders.

The cry that the crushing pressure kept him from voicing echoed only in his heart.

It's the divine spirit. The divine spirit of Dongting Lake has revealed itself!

The world was filled with more superstitions than anyone could count, and Hubei Province was no exception.

An old man told a child, and when that child grew old, he told another child. Stories passed from mouth to mouth for hundreds of years.

The old boatman was no different.

A native of Hubei Province who had spent his entire life on the water, he knew the identity of the being he called a divine spirit.

The Two-Horned Beast of Dongting Lake.

The Water God Dragon.

The true master of Dongting Lake.

Ah… ahhh…

The old boatman trembled violently. His entire body shook beneath an emotion he could not understand, and something swelled within his chest.

[2216] A hundred *jang* is about 303 meters (994 ft).

It was an emotion only he, among everyone present, could feel.

Awe and fear too profound to put into words.

A boatman to the marrow of his bones, he could not believe that he had come face-to-face with the master of Dongting Lake. The aura flowing from that being left him struggling to breathe.

The divine spirit is angry. All of this happened because the divine spirit was enraged!

The old boatman realized that his guess had been correct.

The countless deaths that had occurred one after another over the past month. He did not know why, but the divine spirit had certainly been angered beyond measure.

And in the end, it would punish him just as it had punished the others.

With death!

He could not die like this. Somehow, he had to calm the divine spirit's anger.

A cracked cry burst from the old boatman's mouth as he stood there, entranced.

"D-Divine Spirit! This humble one has committed no sin!"

The silence that had settled over everyone shattered. The old boatman's cry scattered into the wind and rain.

Before the others, frozen rigid by the colossal being's appearance, could stop him, the old boatman ran toward the water on trembling legs.

"Divine Spiriiit!"

Tap-tap-tap, splash!

The instant the old boatman's shabby straw sandals touched the water of Dongting Lake—

Swish.

In a world that had slowed to a crawl, a gigantic pair of eyes turned toward him.

The old boatman's reflection appeared in those blood-red vertical pupils. As the creature registered the tiny, insignificant human, the light in its eyes blazed crimson.

Whooooooosh!

A chilling aura erupted in every direction from the thirty-*jang*[2217] body.

Birds in flight lost their strength and plummeted. Thousands of fish fleeing in schools through the depths of Dongting Lake floated belly-up to the surface.

An aura as immense as its body, an aura akin to death.

Neither insignificant creatures nor even humans could remain unharmed before it.

Before that invisible aura even reached him, the old boatman's entire body had already stiffened like a stone statue.

[2217] Thirty *jang* is about 91 meters (298 ft).

His mouth hung open, his eyes bulged wide. Just as his pupils began to roll white beneath the grip of terror—

Whoosh! Thud!

A sharp whistle cut through the air, and the old boatman crumpled where he stood.

A young man gently caught his frail body, then raised his head and stared at the enormous being.

“Hey, you fucking eel bastard.”

…!

At the clear voice, the enormous being’s pupils swelled as though it had realized something.

Different.

Every other human on the ground had frozen from shock and fear, but this young man was different. He was neither stunned nor trembling.

Fear of the unknown came from confronting something incomprehensible.

But that young man was free from it all. More than fearless, he almost seemed accustomed to this.

Just like now.

“Can’t you open those eyes properly?”

With that offhand remark from the young man, Jin Taekyung, a streak of light tore through the air.

Whooooooosh! Bam!

When I first saw the thing, only one thought flashed through my mind.

Am I seeing things?

I could hardly have thought otherwise. A monster I had seen somewhere before had appeared right in front of me—not in the modern world, but in Murim.

If it had merely been an illustration in some fantasy novel, that would have been one thing. Unfortunately, I recognized it from the *Monster Encyclopedia*, compiled over the past several decades by countless leading scholars and Hunters who had fought in the Great Cataclysm.

Could that be…?

Although the monsters I had fought most often during my Hunter career had been low-level creatures like goblins, the section I had looked at most in the *Monster Encyclopedia* was the one covering the highest-level monsters.

And that thing was one of the monsters given a particularly large entry.

…A Sea Serpent.

As its name suggested, a Sea Serpent was a marine monster.

In the early days of the Great Cataclysm, a Sea Serpent had announced its existence to the entire world by sinking a US carrier battle group. For some reason, it vanished shortly after the Great Cataclysm.

No, let me correct that.

At least, that had been true until a moment ago.

A Sea Serpent in Murim? What the hell is going on…?

I had frozen in shock, but I soon noticed something strange.

Wait. Something's different.

In the modern world where I had been born and raised, the Sea Serpent was not some fictional monster that appeared only in mythology.

It was one of the highest-level monsters serving the Demon King Asmodeus, as well as one of the major culprits responsible for inflicting terrible damage on humanity.

Naturally, there were high-resolution photographs showing exactly what it looked like, along with preserved video recordings of its battles.

But the monster before me was clearly different from the Sea Serpent depicted in the *Monster Encyclopedia*.

The Sea Serpent looks more like an actual sea snake, but that thing is closer to an Eastern dragon.

The more closely I looked, the more certain I became. There were subtle differences in the size and length of its body, as well as the shape of its face.

But these two similar yet different monsters did share one crucial trait.

Whooooooosh!

It was that.

An inherently ferocious aura possessed only by monsters—fundamentally different from what martial artists called killing intent.

Fear.

Fear was exactly what it sounded like: terror and dread.

Every monster possessed it, but the stronger the monster, the more powerful its Fear became.

It shackled an enemy's body by instilling fear and terror, then shattered the enemy's mind.

Just like the Dongting Fisherman.

The scattered puzzle pieces in my head began falling into place.

The Dongting Fisherman's state, which had seemed almost insane. His clear eyes returning only after all his strength had drained away.

He must have encountered that thing before we did.

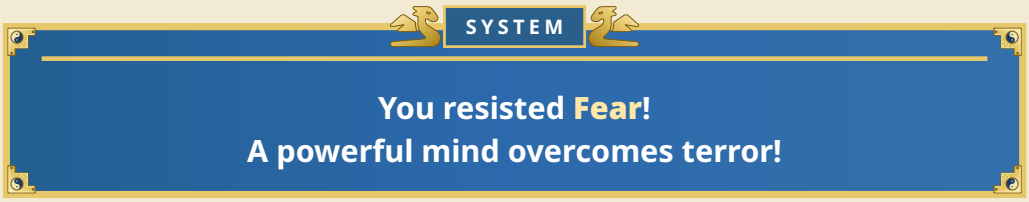
Even a Supreme Peak master with immense martial prowess and an unshakable mind could be overwhelmed by the terror of confronting the unknown for the first time.

When it came to resisting Fear, an S-rank Hunter was probably far better equipped than even a Supreme Peak martial artist.

And…

That goes for me too.

Ding.



Whoosh, thud!

I caught the old boatman's collapsing body as I struck his pressure points.

One second. No, even a quarter of a second later, and the poor old man might have gone mad from Fear—or simply died.

I raised my head and looked at the enormous being towering in the distance.

Damn. It's huge.

I had never fought a Sea Serpent, but this thing was clearly no pushover.

It had just taken a spear I had hurled with all my strength and still hadn't fallen.

Bam!

With a heavy impact, the colossal body, more than thirty *jang*[2218] long, swayed slightly.

It was like watching a small mountain move. I bit my lip.

I couldn't pierce its scales.

I could tell from the sound alone. Even after pouring all my strength into the iron spear I had pulled from my Inventory and hurled, I had failed to inflict any meaningful damage.

If I had used White Flame, forged from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, I could have dealt a more decisive blow.

But if I could not finish it in One Strike, that would be a foolish move.

It was more urgent to act before the enormous monster recovered from its confusion.

I turned and drew a deep breath as I pulled internal energy up from my dantian.

"Cheongpung! Hyuk Mujin! Gung Gibang!"

"Hup!"

[2218] Thirty *jang* is about 91 meters (298 ft).

“Urgh!”

A thunderous shout erupted from my mouth, so loud I could scarcely believe it had come from me. The three men, frozen like stone statues, flinched.

No.

Not three. Two.

Unlike Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin, whose eyes looked as though half their souls had fled their bodies, Cheongpung was staring at me in surprise.

“You startled me. What is it, Benefactor?”

“…?”

What the hell is this guy?

Anyone would freeze after seeing a monster like that. I was the exception because I had grown up in the modern world, surrounded by monsters until I was sick of them.

But Cheongpung had been born and raised in Murim. The fact that he could overcome Fear so easily was astonishing.

“Cheongpung. Are you really all right?”

“Huh? About what?”

“I mean, that thing over there…”

“Oh, right. I was really surprised.”

Cheongpung threw both arms wide and exclaimed emphatically.

“It’s huge! Really huge! I’ve never seen anything like that in my life!”

“…”

I hadn’t thought that through.

Cheongpung had been out of his mind from the beginning.

Chapter 470

What the hell was going on?

Even with every second counting, I blanked out for a moment before finally managing to speak.

“W-Wait a second, Cheongpung.”

“I’ve never seen anything like that in my life! Grandfather was right—the world really is vast! I’m so glad I left Huashan!”

“Yes, the world is vast, but that has absolutely nothing to do with—”

“Whoa! It moved again!”

“…”

He wasn’t listening to a word I said.

I’d known for a long time that Cheongpung was a little unhinged, but I’d never imagined he was this far gone.

What kind of person is this?

Even a veteran Hunter who encountered monsters more often than his own parents would naturally feel fear upon facing a supermassive monster of that size.

But Cheongpung wasn’t merely unaffected by Fear. He was practically beside himself with excitement.

I had underestimated him without realizing it. He wasn’t a little crazy. He was thoroughly insane.

Still, this is much better than having him tremble like the others.

He was different from ordinary people from the very beginning. The fear of the unknown—of an existence no one had ever seen or heard of before—did not apply to Cheongpung.

Because that bastard found everything new and exciting.

Point a gun at a baby who doesn’t even know what a gun is, and it’ll just smile because the thing looks interesting.

I’d stake Hyuk Mujin’s balls on it: even if you turned the entire world upside down and shook it out, Cheongpung would be the only martial artist in all of Murim capable of reacting this way to such an enormous monster.

…Yeah. This is much better.

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin were still half out of their minds.

When we needed every hand we could get, having Cheongpung unaffected by Fear was a tremendous help.

[2219] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity.

I grabbed Cheongpung by the shoulder as he stared with glittering eyes, looking back and forth between the cowering Mimi-chan[2219] and the Mutated Water God Dragon.

“Staring at it like that won’t make it evolve, so snap out of it. Protect the boatman and the Dongting Fisherman first.”

“What about you, Benefactor?”

“I need to get those two back to their senses first.”

Before I’d even finished speaking, I raced forward and slapped Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin across the face.

Smack! Smack!

Two bodies went tumbling away with a pair of satisfyingly meaty cracks.

The two men flailed like people waking from nightmares, then looked up at me with unsteady eyes.

“Gasp—cough.”

“C-Captain.”

I’d put a fair amount of strength into those slaps.

The blows must have split the insides of their mouths, because blood streamed between their parted lips. But Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin didn’t even have the presence of mind to feel the pain.

“I thought it was a dream. Why am I still seeing things?”

“W-What is that?”

Even if my help had pulled them out of Fear’s grip, it couldn’t erase the primal fear inherent in every human being.

As the two men stared blankly over my shoulder, a low, deep roar shook the air.

—Kraaaaaaah!

Damn it. I didn’t need to turn around to know the enormous monster was furious.

Or what was making that terrifying sound as it tore through the air toward us.

“Cheongpung!”

I shouted as I grabbed Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin by the backs of their necks and threw myself aside.

At the same instant, something enormous slammed into the spot where we’d been standing.

Whooooooosh—crash!

Sand and mud erupted with a deafening boom.

The object that had missed us by only a few steps was a jagged boulder nearly one *jang*[2220] tall.

…It threw that all the way here?

[2220] One *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The boulder must have weighed several thousand *geun*[2221] at least, yet it had been hurled from far away.

Its strength was terrifying, but its aim was accurate, too. If I hadn't moved quickly, I would have been crushed to death on the spot.

Look at that control. Did it pitch in the majors?

As I stared at the monster in horror, a familiar notification pierced my ears beneath its enraged roar.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A sudden Quest, Corrupted Spiritual Creature, has been generated.
You cannot refuse the Quest. The Quest has been forcibly accepted!
Logout is unavailable while the Quest is in progress!

Quest
Corrupted Spiritual Creature
For many years, this noble being waited to ascend from the depths of the river. But an unknown power corrupted it.
The spiritual creature that once possessed a brilliant intellect and a beautiful form has become a hideous evil creature.
Because of the countless deaths it has caused, it will never again regain its former appearance.
And now, you must stop this unfortunate yet powerful evil creature.
Dispel the dark clouds hanging over Hubei Province!
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Objective: Defeat the Mutated Water God Dragon (Incomplete)
Reward: Linked Quest
Vast EXP and Fame
???
Failure: Death or an equivalent penalty

I scanned the Quest window at lightning speed. My assessment was short and simple.

"…What a load of crap."

It was the worst Quest imaginable for the worst possible situation.

[2221] One Korean *geun* is approximately 600 g (1.32 lb).

First, the Quest had been forcibly accepted. Then Logout had been disabled. On top of that, the System had nailed the door shut so I couldn't even run if things went badly.

Either I killed that enormous monster or I died here.

The System was demanding that I choose one of those two options.

And it says death or an equivalent penalty. What the hell kind of penalty is that supposed to be?

I didn't even want to think about it. No—to be precise, I wasn't given another moment to think.

Boom! Whooooooosh!

The next instant, I saw it.

Beyond the semitransparent holographic window, a distant cliff collapsed. Dozens of black dots filled the sky high overhead, plummeting toward us like meteors.

Faced with that incredible sight, Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang muttered blankly.

"Are those stars? Yeah. They must be stars."

"They're too dark to be stars. And they're getting closer."

"Stars are all like that these days."

"Come to think of it, that's true. Captain, you always tell me to throw away my preconceptions, but…"

"You two crazy bastards!"

Grab—whooooooosh!

I seized the two men, who still hadn't come to their senses and were spouting nonsense, and threw myself aside.

Cheongpung was already moving too, with the Dongting Fisherman—who had passed out again after delivering his warning—tucked under one arm and the old boatman under the other.

"Benefactor! They're big! And there are lots of them!"

His language skills were on an elementary-school level, but that was more than enough to understand what he meant. Even I could see that there were far too many of those bizarre boulders falling toward us.

They would blanket every inch of the narrow patch of ground beneath us—and then some.

Whooooooosh!

Damn it. There was nowhere to dodge.

As I threw the two men behind me, I recited the activation command in my mind.

Open Inventory. Summon.

White Flame appeared in my hand just as the shadow of an enormous boulder fell over me.

Without hesitation, I drew up every bit of internal energy in my body and swept the spearhead through the air.

Shh-shh-shh-shing!

Blue-white Force erupted from the spearhead and tore through the air.

It shot toward the jagged boulders that had spent countless ages accumulating sediment and weathering as part of the cliff.

Split.

Schk!

Force was a concentrated manifestation of energy capable of cutting steel like soft tofu. The bizarre boulders caught in the arc traced by my spearhead broke into pieces and began to fall.

Boom!

Sand and river water surged upward with a boom that shook the ground.

Amid the shrill screams of Hyuk Mujin and Gung Gibang, I saw Cheongpung escape the same way I had.

However…

Crack!

Damn it. I forgot about that.

My stomach twisted at the sight of the ferryboat's shattered remains. It had been smashed so thoroughly that not a trace of its original shape remained.

If the old boatman had been awake to see what had happened to his boat, he might have fainted.

If we stay here, we'll be nothing but targets. I need to use the wreckage to move us, at least for now—

Before I could finish the thought, my body suddenly locked up.

In my brief glance across the water, something that should have been there was missing.

The enormous creature that had towered amid the raging river and flashing lightning had vanished without a trace.

This is—

A red alert blared through my mind.

My eyes flew wide, and I screamed a warning.

"It's coming!"

And in the next instant—

Kwaaaaaaah!

A wall of water more than ten *jang*[2222] high surged into the air, and a body far darker and larger than the jagged boulders blotted out the blackened sky.

[2222] One *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

A familiar face—mine—was reflected in its long, vertical, blood-red pupils.

—Grrrrrrrr.

The breath spilling from the maw of that corrupted evil beast was chillingly cold. Its enormous body, larger than any monster I had ever seen, radiated killing intent and pressure that crushed down on everything around it.

What kind of monster is this…!

I was staring up at it in shock when it happened.

Shra-ra-ra-ra-ra!

Countless streaks of light rained down from every direction.

The whiskers surrounding the bridge of its nose, which was covered in hard scales, split into hundreds of strands and plunged toward me.

Each was several *jang*[2223] long. Some shot forward in straight lines, while others curved like living creatures to attack from my blind spots.

"…!"

I wasn't even given time to shout.

Every hair on my body stood on end, and all my senses opened wide. In a world that had slowed to a crawl, I twisted aside.

Thud-thud-thud-thud! Slash!

Scorching pain spread from my shoulder. It was obvious who the drops of blood spattering across the muddy water belonged to.

Still, if I'd escaped an unexpected attack with nothing worse than this, I'd gotten off cheap.

Now it was time to make the monster pay a much higher price.

"Hah!"

Schk!

The spearhead I swung with a battle cry cut through dozens of whiskers.

The long, flaming tail of the **Fire Dragon's Single Tail**, befitting the form's name, did not stop there. It cut through the air and swept toward the monster's jaw.

Whoooooosh!

Alongside a deafening sound of something splitting the air, everything around me turned black.

In a world so slow it seemed to have stopped, I finally saw it.

Something was sweeping toward me from the side in a massive arc.

Ah, fuck. The tail.

The instant I realized what it was, an enormous impact tore through my entire body.

Boom!

[2223] One *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

My clear vision blurred.

In less than a second, heaven and earth flipped over countless times, and everything around me shook as though an earthquake had struck.

No. That wasn't right.

I was the only thing flipping and shaking.

By the time my thoughts untangled from the impact, I had already flown more than ten *jang*[2224] and was hurtling toward the cliff.

Damn it. I need to dodge, even now…

But after taking a blow packed with such tremendous force, I couldn't move properly.

I gritted my teeth and braced myself for the second impact.

No.

I tried to brace myself.

Thud. Krrrraaaack!

A light impact reached me through my back. Then my speed began to decrease as the ground was churned up beneath me.

As I blinked, someone's voice reached my ears.

"Are you all right, Benefactor?"

It was Cheongpung.

I released the breath I'd been holding and got my feet under me. Then I realized why the Quest's Grade was Supreme Peak instead of a question mark.

"Hey, you goddamn eel bastard!"

At the sound of that familiar voice, I let out a quiet laugh.

[2224] One *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 471

Fire King Jeok Cheongang had lived for well over a hundred years.

The boy who had wandered the streets begging for food met a master one day and became the eighteenth successor of the Fire Gate Clan. Years later, when his master returned to the earth, he became the clan's sole Disciple and Sect Leader.

The boy became a young man, the young man reached middle age, and the middle-aged man finally grew old. It had been a long, long journey.

In that time, a great war erupted that would determine the fate of the world. A new nation arose, and even the surname of the Son of Heaven[2225] changed.

Five floods and earthquakes struck. Plagues spread, and bands of Red Turbans[2226] rose throughout the land, pillaging wherever they went.

Among everything Jeok Cheongang had witnessed, there had been disasters wrought by human hands and divine punishments sent down by the heavens.

But one event had left a deeper, greater mark on his life than any other.

The Great Faction War.

An age when corpses formed mountains and blood flowed in rivers.

Amid the maelstrom of that war, Jeok Cheongang had glimpsed a vast world of demonic, heterodox arts unlike anything he had ever known.

The Demonic Path martial arts of the Heavenly Demon Divine Cult rivaled those of Shaolin Temple—the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper[2227] of the Murim's orthodox faction—in depth and breadth. They were sinister and bizarre.

But now, Jeok Cheongang understood.

Even everything he had seen and experienced throughout his long life amounted to no more than a drop in the bucket compared to the scene unfolding before his eyes.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

What in the world…?

The moment that enormous being finally revealed itself, Jeok Cheongang felt the blood freeze in his veins.

What on earth is that thing?

He was a master from two generations past, well beyond his ninety-ninth year.

Given his age and standing, he had seen no small number of spiritual creatures and evil beasts that ordinary martial artists might never encounter even once in their lives.

[2225] Son of Heaven is a traditional Chinese title for the Emperor.

[2226] The Red Turbans were rebel groups associated with the upheaval at the end of China's Yuan dynasty, named for their red headwear.

[2227] Mount Tai and the Northern Dipper are enduring landmarks invoked together as a metaphor for a preeminent authority.

But that being…

It was different. It surpassed every scrap of experience and knowledge Fire King Jeok Cheongang possessed.

The monster was not merely destroying the cliff.

The laws and order of the world he had always believed in were crumbling along with the jagged boulders, shattered and scattered beyond recognition.

And Jeok Cheongang was not alone in his shock.

“Ha.”

“Ah, ahhh!”

The greatest assassin of all time, known as the Slaughter Saint, could not suppress his astonished sigh. Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng, whose knowledge and genius were said to rival those of Zhuge Wuhou,[2228] was struck speechless.

But that was not the end of their shock.

—Kraaaaaaaaaah!

The enormous monster’s roar drove back the rain and blasted apart the wind.

At the same time, a chilling aura spread outward from the monster and swept over all three men standing more than a hundred *jang*[2229] away.

Whooooooosh!

“…”

“…”

“…”

The three figures stiffened as one. Their eyes widened involuntarily, all three pairs filled with unmistakable shock.

How can this be!

Their bodies felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton, and their hands clenched on their own.

Zhuge Feng, who still remained at the Peak realm, let out a faint groan as a tremendous chill ran through him. Even Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong, who stood in realms far beyond his, caught their breath in surprise.

Th-This is…!

Impossible.

The two extraordinary martial artists known as the Fire King and the Slaughter Saint immediately realized the identity of the unfamiliar sensation that had come over them.

[2228] Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific for Zhuge Liang, the statesman and strategist of China’s Three Kingdoms period.

[2229] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

It was an emotion they had forgotten long ago. A stale, ancient emotion they had been unable to feel since becoming beings so powerful that no one dared approach them.

Fear.

The overwhelming power of the Fear radiating from the Mutated Water God Dragon was partly responsible, but the greater cause was Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong's ignorance.

Their martial arts were unquestionably several levels above those of modern S-rank Hunters. Even so, the sudden appearance of a gigantic monster unlike anything they had ever encountered was more than enough to shake the iron minds of two men who had spent decades establishing their own understanding of the world.

—Kraaaaaaow!

The monster did not miss the opening. It rampaged without restraint.

Each time its black-scaled body slammed against the cliff, enormous jagged boulders filled the sky before crashing down.

Kwagwagwagwang!

A ceaseless rain of boulders hurtled toward somewhere hidden from view by the terrain.

Flames blazed in Jeok Cheongang's eyes as he watched.

You bastard!

He already knew what the unknown monster was attacking so relentlessly.

The sole successor of the Fire Gate Clan and his Disciple.

No—his temporary Disciple, Jin Taekyung.

The moment he remembered that fact, lava-like energy erupted from the body Fear had briefly frozen.

Whoom!

Several jiazi's[2230] worth of Scorching Yang Qi surged through his Twelve Regular Meridians and Eight Extraordinary Meridians, driving back the aura pouring from the unknown being.

Scorching heat flooded his immobilized body, if only for an instant. Then he unleashed a battle cry like a thunderclap.

"Ha—!"

Bang!

The internal energy carried in his shout was so immense that the air and raindrops surrounding the three men burst apart.

[2230] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

Jeok Cheongang had not yet escaped Fear's influence completely. Yet despite being exposed to Fear for the first time in his life, he had broken free on his own, without anyone's help.

Any modern Hunter who witnessed it would have doubted their own eyes.

But Jeok Cheongang was not the only one to accomplish such an astonishing feat.

While Jeok Cheongang dispelled part of the Fear through rage, Mungyeong overcame its oppression with cold reason and enlightenment half a step higher than Jeok Cheongang's.

An evil beast unheard of in all of history. It must be brought down here and now.

The young medical apprentice who always tended warmly to the sick was no longer there.

The greatest assassin of all time, feared by everyone beneath the heavens, stepped forward with calm eyes. His slender figure scattered like an illusion.

Tap. Whooooooosh!

The Slaughter Saint's signature martial art, the Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step, shot forward, pressing down the current and treading upon the raindrops.

His figure streaked ahead like a beam of light, leaving only a pale afterimage behind. Beneath him, a single trail of flame raced forward, evaporating every trace of moisture around it.

Whoom!

A furious roar erupted from Jeok Cheongang's lips.

"You heaven-cursed eel bastard! Get away from that boy this instant!"

Rumble, crash!

A sharp, ringing shout pierced the ceaseless thunder as two figures charged toward the gigantic Water God Dragon like bolts of lightning.

Only now did I finally understand why the Quest's Grade was Supreme Peak.

It might have been tough on my own, but this changes everything.

There was Cheongpung, a genuine Supreme Peak master and a genius whose ability to learn and apply martial arts surpassed even mine, despite the System.

And then there were two beings who needed no embellishment whatsoever.

The Fire King and the Slaughter Saint. The Slaughter Saint and the Fire King.

Even by the standards of the modern world, where average life expectancy had risen dramatically, those two were old enough to be playing gateball[2231] in a retirement community.

[2231] Gateball is a mallet-and-ball game related to croquet and played especially by older adults in East Asia.

Yet they were monsters capable of knocking a Peak master's head clean off with a single finger.

Their movements do look a little heavier than before…

Had those two been affected by Fear as well, even if only slightly?

Whatever the case, two more human-shaped monsters had joined the fight against the supermassive monster.

I had taken some damage in the initial clash, but aside from the minor Internal Injury I'd suffered while fighting the Dongting Fisherman and the cut on my shoulder, I was perfectly fine.

If not for my insane Muscles and Bones and the Fire Dragon Armor, I might've broken every limb.

The monster moved far faster than its massive body suggested, and it attacked with its whiskers.

I was thinking that it resembled the Sea Serpent I had read about in the *Monster Encyclopedia*, yet differed from it in several ways, when—

—Grrrrrrr…!

In that split second, the Water God Dragon's eyes flashed as it finally realized the situation was taking an unusual turn.

I did not miss that brief opening.

"Cheongpung!"

"Yes, Benefactor!"

Sometimes, a single word or exchanged glance was enough for two people to understand each other.

That was exactly what happened as Cheongpung and I charged toward the Water God Dragon the instant I shouted.

Whoooooosh!

Shh-shh-shh-shing!

We moved twice as fast as I had when the dragon's tail sent me flying.

Blue and red Force surged along spearhead and sword blade as we bore down on it, and the Water God Dragon's whiskers thrashed violently.

Shri-ri-ri-rik!

Those whiskers were the absolute worst.

The power carried in each one did not quite equal the Force of a Supreme Peak master, but their destructive power and sharpness surpassed ordinary Sword Energy. They could not be ignored.

On top of that, each strand was roughly three *jang*[2232] long, and their trajectories were bizarre and impossible to predict, much like the Dongting Fisherman's martial arts when he wielded his black-wood fishing rod.

[2232] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

The only reason the first attack had landed was that I hadn't known the bastard could control hundreds of whiskers like that.

But…

Come at me again, you son of a bitch.

Streaks of light filled with the Water God Dragon's power poured toward me from every direction. I slashed the spearhead diagonally downward before me.

Whooooooom! Schk!

The streaks of light caught in the path of the blue-white flames lost their power and were sliced apart.

But the Water God Dragon was no pushover. Just as many streaks as I had cut down were already coming for my back.

Whoosh!

I had sensed it from the beginning, but the bastard was definitely intelligent. Perhaps it had instinctively recognized the strength of the Fire Dragon Armor, because its attacks drove toward the bare flesh the armor did not cover.

My back went cold as I felt the killing intent hurtling toward me.

But an instant ahead of it, a powerful force came rushing in.

Shik. Schk!

Brilliant violet Force drove away the darkness and lit up the world.

The Zaha Divine Technique, a secret ultimate art taught only to Huashan's direct Disciples.

Cheongpung.

I felt the killing intent aimed at my back disappear.

There was no need to turn and check. Cheongpung had done his part perfectly.

Now it was my turn to unleash my full strength.

No. Correction.

It was our turn.

—Grrrrrrrrk!

The Mutated Water God Dragon jerked its head up, but it was already too late.

Its greatest mistake had been failing to stop Cheongpung and me quickly enough. Two human-shaped monsters were already closing in behind its enormous body.

Shik!

Silent and stealthy, yet faster than anything else, a single bolt of lightning plunged from the air.

A moment later, the sound of something being severed rang out.

Schk!

One of the Water God Dragon's black horns was cut in half the instant it met the silver Force. A roar that might have been pain or rage burst from the monster's maw.

—Graaaargh!

“Gasp!”

Mungyeong’s figure shook as he tried to thrust a small sword between the Water God Dragon’s scales.

My guess was right.

Unlike me, who was accustomed to a monster’s Fear, or Cheongpung, who had been insane from the beginning, the others had not yet escaped Fear’s influence completely, though it affected each of them differently.

But that did not stop the fist Jeok Cheongang had already launched.

“You godforsaken son of a bitch—!”

Jeok Cheongang spewed the curse like a magic incantation, and his fist slammed into the Water God Dragon’s midsection.

Fwoosh! Boom!

—Kra-ra-ra-ra-ra!

A tremendous burst of flame and steam exploded outward, and the Water God Dragon’s gigantic body tilted toward the ground.

Its maw was falling directly toward me as I charged forward with all my strength.

Whooooooosh!

—Krrk!

My reflection appeared in its enormous blood-red pupil, split vertically down the middle—White Flame thrust forward, wreathed in blue fire.

“I told you not to open those eyes like that, you sibu-leol[2233] bastard.”

Shnk!

[2233] *Sibu-leol* renders a coarse Korean expletive used here to intensify the insult.

Chapter 472

Shnk!

The heat boring through its pupil was scorching, but the pain that followed was cold enough to numb the senses.

As agony spread through it like fire, the Mutated Water God Dragon unleashed a pain-filled roar.

—Kraaaaaaaaaah!

Its torso was as thick as a dozen or so full-grown trees bundled together, and its length easily exceeded thirty *jang*[2234].

When that enormous body, like a small mountain, began thrashing wildly, the shock waves swept through everything around it.

Boom! Kwoom-kwoom-kwoom!

The bizarre boulders it had hurled earlier exploded into hundreds, then thousands of fragments, while walls of dirt and water surged into the air.

The entire area was being devastated as though under concentrated bombardment, yet several figures raced swiftly through the chaos.

Shh-shh-shik!

Some charged toward the monster. Others retreated beyond the reach of its thrashing body. Zhuge Feng—the current Family Head of the Zhuge Clan and the Crouching Dragon Guest[2235]—belonged to the latter group.

Having finally regained his senses, he stared in bewilderment at the scene before him.

It isn't enough that the heavenly patterns are becoming distorted. Now beings of supernatural powers are appearing too?

Zhuge Feng possessed extensive knowledge of creatures known as spiritual creatures or evil creatures, but this dragon-like monster defied everything he knew.

If word of what had happened here today reached the outside world, not only Murim but the entire realm would be thrown into an uproar.

How could something like this happen…?

Zhuge Feng was still trembling from the fear that had yet to fade completely when someone spoke to him.

"Stay here with the others. Hide behind cover and keep yourselves as safe as possible."

[2234] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty *jang* is about 91 m (298 ft), and two *jang* is about 6.06 m (19.9 ft).

[2235] "Crouching Dragon" alludes to Zhuge Liang, the Chinese strategist associated with that epithet.

Any martial artist would have felt his pride wounded by those words. Martial artists were the sort of people who staked their lives on their martial arts and a single sword as they wandered through a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords.

Zhuge Feng looked at the other person with a stiff expression and opened his mouth.

“Who am I?”

“Pardon?”

“I asked if you know who I am.”

Cheongpung answered.

“Yes. Great Hero Zhuge Pong.”

“It’s Zhuge Feng, not Zhuge Pong. In any case, you do know that I’m the Family Head of the Zhuge Clan.”

“Uh, yes, I do…”

“And yet you’re telling the Family Head of the Zhuge Clan to hide like a coward?”

Cheongpung thought for a moment, then nodded.

“That would be much safer.”

“Good. Then I’d better stay right here and not move.”

“Pardon?”

“Didn’t you say this place was safe? Better to be a coward than die like a dog for no reason.”

“…?”

“Don’t look at me like that. It’s simply that this isn’t a battle I need to fight today. It’s the same reason Zhuge Wuhou[2236], our family’s ancestor, did not stand at the vanguard and cut down the enemy.”

Zhuge Feng knew exactly where he stood and what he needed to do.

He was too clearheaded to wager his life on a martial artist’s pride, and as a Family Head, he was responsible for countless members of his household.

“This great war has only just begun. The day will come when I prove my worth in the battles ahead. So go on. I’ll protect these people.”

Cheongpung regarded Zhuge Feng with a strange look, then turned away with a small bow.

As the young man became a gust of wind and vanished into the distance, Zhuge Feng’s gaze grew somber.

Yes. The beginning of another age of chaos.

The peace that had lasted for more than fifty years was over. Dark clouds filled the blackened sky, and new winds were blowing in from every direction.

[2236]Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific title for Zhuge Liang, a Chinese statesman and military strategist; “Wuhou” is its shortened form here.

Cheongpung, racing toward the distant battlefield, was one of those winds.

Wuhou[2237]. At least for today, it seems there is no place for this unworthy descendant to step forward.

Just as Zhuge Feng murmured those words to himself, a dazed conversation behind him drifted into his ears.

“I can see a monster over there. Is this a dream?”

“I don’t think it’s a dream. No, wait. Maybe it is.”

“But Hyuk, why are your pants so wet?”

“It’s raining. They must’ve gotten wet.”

“That’s awfully bright yellow for rainwater.”

“That can happen.”

“Can it? How strange. Anyway, isn’t this really a dream?”

“I don’t think it’s a dream. No, wait. Maybe it is.”

“But Hyuk, why are your pants so wet—”

“…”

After listening to the utterly incoherent exchange, Zhuge Feng quietly shifted away from the stench of urine.

He stood atop a hill where layer upon layer of dirt and sand had formed a small mound. In the direction of his gaze, a battle straight out of myth was unfolding.

Shhk, schk!

A silver line cleaved through space, cutting apart everything rushing toward him.

Papat!

Mungyeong vanished like an illusion, then sprang upward from a fragment of stone suspended in midair.

Whooooooosh!

Something enormous came hurtling through the spray and clouds of dust.

It did not take him long to realize that it was a tail covered in black scales.

Fast. Even faster than I expected.

It moved with a speed that seemed impossible for a body of such tremendous size. Drawing a breath, Mungyeong tightened his grip on his short sword.

Tsstsstssts!

Internal energy rose silently, yet with the speed of a lightning bolt, and enveloped the short sword.

[2237] Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific title for Zhuge Liang, a Chinese statesman and military strategist; “Wuhou” is its shortened form here.

Power more destructive and keener than anything else in the world. Force surged along the blade.

A single technique embodying the principle of extreme swiftness flowed from the fingertips of the greatest assassin of all time.

I'll sever it in one stroke.

The next instant, Mungyeong brought his sword down diagonally toward the incoming tail—and realized he had miscalculated.

Schk.

The blade had undeniably cut into it, yet the resistance was absurdly strong.

The Force imbued in his short sword had to cut through more than the black scales.

Beneath those steel-hard scales lay ironlike flesh and muscle, as well as bones of incredible strength.

Damn.

Mungyeong clicked his tongue inwardly.

This was Force—and not just any Force, but Force infused with the enlightenment of the greatest assassin of all time.

No matter how tough the monster's body was, his Force could have cut through it in a single stroke.

The problem was its thickness.

The monstrous tail was two *jang*[2238] in diameter.

Combined with flesh far tougher than he had anticipated…

I can't sever it in one strike.

Perhaps he could have under normal circumstances, but he had yet to shake off the lingering effects of Fear. He knew better than anyone that he could not bring his full martial prowess to bear.

In that case…

The instant he reached his decision, Mungyeong twisted the wrist holding the sword hilt.

The blade had already cut through the scales and was carving into the flesh and muscle beneath them. It rotated smoothly, using its flat to divert the force behind the tail.

Ka-ga-gak! Whoom!

His small, slender figure was flung backward through the air.

Boom!

[2238] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty *jang* is about 91 m (298 ft), and two *jang* is about 6.06 m (19.9 ft).

Mungyeong twisted in midair and landed with a rough movement wholly unsuited to the name Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step. Beside him, Jeok Cheongang melted an incoming boulder with a single palm strike and spoke in a mocking tone.

“Did your martial arts become childish too after you Returned to Youth[2239]?”

“Its strength and speed both far exceeded my expectations. Even with the principle of Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties, I couldn’t redirect it completely.”

“Your tongue got longer too.”

Mungyeong gave Jeok Cheongang a dry sidelong glance.

“If you’re trying to taunt me, stop here. The timing seems rather poor.”

“It isn’t a taunt. It’s an undeniable fact. Didn’t you see that thing crumple when this old man hit it once?”

“That was after I had already cut off its horn—”

Shri-ri-ri-rik! Boom!

A thunderous explosion swallowed the rest of Mungyeong’s words.

As though they had planned it, both men launched themselves away at the same instant. They clicked their tongues as they watched a streak of light writhe like a living creature.

The spot where they had stood moments earlier had been completely devastated.

“The more I see, the stranger that thing gets. An evil creature using Force?”

“It falls short of Force, yet it’s too powerful to be called Sword Energy. It clearly isn’t using a cultivation technique… but the mere fact that it can perform such a feat with the energy it has accumulated over countless years is almost impossible to believe.”

Harboring energy and being able to use or release that energy were entirely different matters.

In that respect, the monster before them had far surpassed the common sense of both men.

Was that thing also responsible for wiping out Yangtze One Saber and Donghu Stronghold?

Mungyeong dodged another incoming attack and regarded the monster with a deep gaze.

He had assumed that at least two Supreme Peak masters had attacked Donghu Stronghold. But after encountering that unimaginable monster, he finally felt that he understood what had happened.

Those bizarre whiskers and that enormous body… There’s no mistake. They resemble the traces left on the corpses.

[2239] Returned to Youth refers to a martial-arts-fiction phenomenon in which advanced attainment restores a person’s youthful appearance.

He could clearly picture the monster crushing and cutting down everything in its path with its tail and whiskers.

The mystery surrounding Yangtze One Saber's corpse—which everyone had believed had been ravaged by schools of fish—was also solved.

He wasn't torn apart and eaten after he died. He died because he was torn apart and eaten.

Who could possibly have imagined it?

A gigantic dragon-like monster had carried out the slaughter after traveling through a deep underwater tributary inaccessible even to boats—a passage only fish could enter and leave.

If it had never shown itself, then of course there had been no witnesses.

"What a monster."

Mungyeong had no choice but to admit it. The creature possessed strength comparable to hundreds of Peak masters, or perhaps two or three Supreme Peak masters. It was truly a being of supernatural powers.

Jeok Cheongang nodded in agreement.

"That's right. A monster."

"I never imagined such an inexplicable being could truly exist."

"That guy never ceases to amaze me. He always leaves me wondering what might have happened if this old man had been given more time. Just a little more time."

"What are you—"

Mungyeong suddenly remembered something and turned toward Jeok Cheongang. A broad smile filled the old man's wrinkled face, where the passage of time could no longer be concealed.

"Hey, Slaughter Saint. Do you know something?"

Whoooooosh!

An enormous shadow descended with enough momentum to split the world apart.

Jeok Cheongang looked up at the black tail falling toward his small body and slowly continued.

"That one is the strangest and most terrifying monster this old man has ever seen."

"Look out!"

Mungyeong's eyes widened.

Boom-boom-boom! Fwoooosh!

A tremendous roar and vibration spread across a radius of several dozen *jang*[2240].

At the center of it all, Jeok Cheongang stood tall and completely unscathed.

He had not moved a single step from where he had been standing, yet the black-scaled tail had struck far off to one side.

[2240] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty *jang* is about 91 m (298 ft), and two *jang* is about 6.06 m (19.9 ft).

“Yes, that’s right. A monster should be fought by a monster.”

“…!”

Drip-drip-drip.

Above Jeok Cheongang’s head, where he laughed aloud, the monster’s dark-blue blood poured down mixed with the rain and wind.

Mungyeong turned toward the monster’s enormous body. Cheongpung, who had just returned to the battlefield, did the same.

At last, they saw it.

—Gwooooooooooah!

The monster thrashing wildly—and someone dangling from its head at a dizzying height, ripping out its whiskers with his bare hands.

“Bald head! Baldy! Smooth, shiny baldy!”

Pop! Pop! Pop-pop-pop-pop!

—Krooooooooooah!

The Water God Dragon’s mournful wail rang out through the wind and rain.

Chapter 473

Puhuk!

The Mutated Water God Dragon.

The instant I drove the tip of White Flame into its enormous eye, I realized something.

Hard. And deep.

It felt like plunging my hand into a cave with no visible end.

If it had been an ordinary human or beast, this single strike would have melted not only its eye but its entire head without a trace.

But this thing was different.

What the…!

Its head was so enormous that even after I drove White Flame in as far as it would go, the Force wrapped around the spearhead could not reach deep enough inside.

On top of that, the bones and flesh within were absurdly tough.

I was still reeling from resistance far beyond anything I had expected when the Mutated Water God Dragon let out a scream of agony.

—Kraaaaaaaaaah!

I had failed to finish it with my decisive strike, but that did not mean I had failed to inflict any damage.

The Scorching Yang Qi carried by the spearhead had melted one of its eyes.

Its enormous body writhed in excruciating pain. At the same time, a familiar System notification pierced my ears.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Lv. ??? Mutated Water God Dragon is overwhelmed by pain and rage it has never experienced before!

Enters Berserk Status!

Due to Berserk, all of the target's stats increase! However, because it has momentarily lost its reason, its judgment in combat is clouded!

"…Huh?"

The moment I heard the System notification, I nearly lost my own reason.

Damn it. What the hell is this Berserk bullshit?

Do your damn job properly, System. It was already a monster. If it got even stronger, how was I supposed to make a living?

But the System had already activated, and the water was already spilled.

The Water God Dragon's only remaining eye turned completely bloodred, and its Berserk Status began in earnest.

—Kyaaaaaaaaaow!

A roar shook heaven and earth, and an enormous gust of wind slammed into my entire body.

Before I could even blink, a cliff rushed right up to my face.

Oh. I'm fucked.

Kwaang!

A tremendous shock wave crashed over me with a roar that seemed to split the sky apart. My vision blurred, and my eyes lost focus.

The Water God Dragon had slammed its head into the cliff with tens of thousands—perhaps hundreds of thousands—of *geun*[2241] of force, but it did not stop there.

Whooooooosh!

The length of its torso exposed above the water alone was more than thirty *jang*.[2242] Counting the portion still submerged, it was comparable in size to a modern aircraft carrier.

Once a monster that enormous began rampaging like a mad thing, nothing could stop it.

Kwaang! Kwang! Kwagwagwagwang!

It repeatedly smashed its head into the cliff and the river, lashed out with its tail, and sometimes flapped its entire body like a fish caught on a hook.

Every movement devastated the surrounding area, sending countless fragments of rock and blasts of wind crashing down on me.

Just like now.

Ppeok!

"…Hng!"

Damn it. Of all places, my back had slammed into a sharp, jutting rock.

Searing pain raced up my spine, but I gritted my teeth and swallowed my groan.

This was the Water God Dragon's desperate attempt to throw me off. If I fell now, it might counterattack instead.

I tightened my grip on White Flame, still driven deep into the bastard's eye, and fought to keep my balance as its enormous body bucked wildly beneath me.

"You… fucking bastard!"

If it thought something this pathetic would throw me off, it had another thing coming.

I wrapped one hand tightly around the spear shaft and grasped at something invisible with the other.

[2241] A Korean *geun* is a unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb); here it describes the force of the impact.

[2242] A *jang* is ten *cheok*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty *jang* is about 91 m (298 ft).

At the moment, my hand was clutching nothing but empty air.

But that was about to change.

I had a magical command that only I could use.

Inventory Open. Summon.

Shhk. Tak.

The instant I gave the command, the hilt of a sharp short sword appeared in my hand.

The only sword technique I had ever learned was the basic swordsmanship taught at the Hunter training center.

But in a situation like this, who cared about sword technique?

Faster than anyone else, different from everyone else. It was time to become a sashimi master, working to a whole new rhythm atop his cutting board.

"From now on, your name is live-fish sashimi. Or maybe bone-in sashimi."[2243]

I made the solemn declaration and drove the short sword, its blade wrapped in blue-white Scorching Yang Qi, straight into its flesh.

Puk!

The blade was too short to stab very deeply, but the creature's reaction made it clear that it hurt.

Its firm, pale flesh split apart as though consumed by fire, and dark-blue blood burst out.

"You're pink on the inside? Doesn't suit you, asshole."

—Krrrk!

A groan burst from the creature's maw, and its body faltered for a moment.

I did not miss the opening. I swung the short sword again.

Schk! Puhuk!

—Krrrrrk!

Puh-puh-puh-puh-puhuk!

—Kraaaaaaaaaah!

Sword technique? There was no such thing.

I simply hacked and stabbed wherever my hand went and wherever my eyes landed.

After shattering bone and slicing through flesh, the blade withdrew and shot forward again faster than a flash of light. Each time it did, the creature's screams and thrashing grew more violent.

Huh. This is actually useful at a time like this.

[2243] *Hwal-eo-hoe* is raw fish prepared from live fish, while *sekkosi* is thinly sliced raw fish served with the bones left in.

My physical abilities, which could be called superhuman, certainly played a part. But the wrist snap I had trained through the USB—a treasure of humanity—was enough to make even a Peak sword master yield a move.

Ah. So this is All Streams Returning to the Source…[2244]

When had it been?

Shortly after I attained sagehood, I had decided to destroy the USB, and Jinho had tried to stop me.

His words flashed through my mind.

“Taekyung, remember the words left behind by our ancient ancestors. A ghost who dies after getting one off has a healthy glow. Getting one off is always worth it.”

“…Which ancestor said that?”

“Does that matter? The problem is that you’re about to destroy a national-treasure-grade cultural artifact. If you erase that thing, I’ll report you directly to the Cultural Heritage Administration. You’re looking at a minimum of twenty-five years in prison with no chance of parole.”

Is he insane?

What did he mean, getting one off? And what was this nonsense about a healthy glow?

Back then, I had nearly taken a swing at him.

But looking back now, those words were unquestionably the greatest saying since the founding of Korea.

I felt profound gratitude toward Jinho and thought of the women who had now become memories.

Thank you, Uehara. I love you, dutiful daughter of the mapo tofu[2245] *restaurant.*

Schk! Puh-puh-puh-puh-puhuk!

—Graaaargh!

Ah, what a *sugoi*[2246] scream.

My gratitude-filled pro-Japanese sword technique gouged into the gaping pupil and drove deeper and deeper inside.

The Mutated Water God Dragon had no choice but to stop attacking its other enemies far below on the ground.

Whooooooosh—Kwaang!

I could not see what had happened, but I could tell from the sound.

As the enormous body convulsed in pain, the tail that had been crashing down toward the ground struck somewhere completely different.

[2244] *Mallyu gwijong* is a martial-arts expression for different paths or techniques ultimately converging on the same principle.

[2245] Mapo tofu is a Sichuan dish of tofu in a spicy sauce, traditionally made with minced meat.

[2246] *Sugoi* is Japanese for “amazing” or “impressive.”

Then, amid the rising dirt and spray, a streak of silver light changed targets and flew toward me.

Chiriririrk!

From the outside, it must have been a bizarre sight.

The monster was using its own whiskers to gouge at its melted eye.

But from where I was, there was nothing funny about it.

Damn it.

No matter how enormous the Mutated Water God Dragon's eye was, the space was far too narrow for me to avoid dozens of whiskers.

Even though I twisted my body as much as possible, the streaks of light moved with the same cunning subtlety as the black-wood fishing rod, slipping past my Fire Dragon Armor and slicing into my bare flesh.

Puhwak!

"Ghk!"

Red blood sprayed out, and searing pain flared all over me.

I had circulated my internal energy as I dodged to protect myself as much as possible, which was the only reason the damage ended there.

If I had been even slightly slower, one of my limbs might have been severed.

Chiriririk!

Dozens of streaks of light flew toward me again.

I endured the rapidly spreading pain and twisted my body.

The silver whiskers, each possessing terrifying cutting power, missed me by a hair's breadth. A chill ran down my spine.

The space is too narrow. I'll be cut to pieces if this continues.

Perhaps it was that sense of crisis that made me hesitate.

While I hesitated, a spear of light, twisted together like a rope into the shape of a spearhead, flew toward my face.

Shwing!

"…!"

It was unbelievably fast.

In the slowed-down world, I stared wide-eyed at the streak of light flying toward me with a sharp sound as it tore through the air.

Countless possibilities and thoughts flashed through my mind.

If I pull out White Flame right now and swing it… No. It's already too late. And I might lose my balance before then.

Even now, the bastard's head was shaking like mad.

If I pulled out White Flame, which was practically acting as a support, I would lose my balance for a split second.

That would be the end.

There has to be a better way. There has to be some better way…

But the time I had been given amounted to no more than a fleeting instant, and the short sword I swung in haste was helplessly knocked away the moment it collided with the streak of light.

No—it shattered into hundreds of fragments.

Kwa-chang!

Perhaps it was only natural.

The power contained in each individual whisker did not reach the level of Force, but it surpassed the Sword Energy of a Peak master.

With that much energy gathered together, there was no way the traitorous sword technique I had learned through the USB could stand against it.

Whoom!

Am I going to get hit like this?

I stared blankly at the destructive force erasing the space between us and rushing toward my face.

What moved me was something close to pure instinct.

Fwoosh—Kwaddeudeuk!

Just as the streak of light was about to pierce through my chest, I found myself gripping it with a hand wreathed in blue-white flames.

It was neither Flame Divine Palm nor Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

It was nothing more than a crude contest of strength. I had dragged up every last trace of energy in my body and thrown it against the attack.

It did not take long for the result of that clash to reveal itself.

Pajik—Puhwak!

Two powerful energies collided, filling my vision with a blinding flash.

And beyond that dazzling radiance, I could see my hand hanging in tatters like a rag and the streak of light, its thickness reduced ever so slightly.

There was no question who held the advantage.

Damn it. The amount of energy inside us isn't even comparable.

I had accumulated a tremendous amount of internal energy through the System's accelerated growth.

But I could not compare with the bastard, a spiritual creature that had accumulated qi for hundreds of years.

Kwa-deu-deuk!

Even this grueling contest of strength was slowly reaching its limit.

I gritted my teeth as pain tore through my hand.

"You live-fish-sashimi bastard!"

I could not let it end here.

I summoned every last ounce of strength I possessed, twisted my body, and yanked hard on the creature's whiskers as though executing a shoulder throw.

It was impossible.

But even if it was, I had to try—

Kwadeudeudeudeuk—Ppok!

"…Huh?"

—Krrk?

I was stunned.

The Mutated Water God Dragon was stunned too.

In the slowed-down world, dozens of whiskers had been torn out by the roots and were fluttering helplessly toward the ground.

What the fuck? Why did those pull out?

Countless thoughts flashed through my mind.

Could they really just come out like that? Were its roots weaker than the whiskers themselves? No, but even so, could this really happen…?

At last, I reached one conclusion.

My strength is really fucking insane.

When I thought about it, this was entirely possible.

My Strength was high enough to knead steel like dough. What was pulling out a few whiskers compared to that?

No matter how enormous a monster the size of an aircraft carrier was, everything had its limits.

Unlike its scales and bones, which boasted tremendous durability, its hair roots were apparently weak enough for my Strength to pull out.

So this is how it works.

This was something only I could do, with my superhuman Strength.

Until now, I had thought only about dodging and cutting.

It had never occurred to me to tear the whiskers out.

With that great enlightenment, I retrieved White Flame and stepped forward.

Shwaaaaaaaaaak!

As I emerged from the pupil, I saw the creature's enormous body frozen stiff in confusion and its remaining eye blinking rapidly.

"You bastard…"

I smiled brightly and tore out its whiskers.

Kwadeudeuk!

Chapter 474

Kwadeudeuk!

The instant Jin Taekyung ripped out dozens of whiskers at once, the Mutated Water God Dragon opened wide its one remaining eye.

—Krrrrrk…!

It could not believe it.

That tiny, insignificant human had torn out its whiskers—with his bare hands, without even a weapon.

It was impossible. It should have been impossible. Even for the Water God Dragon, which had lived for hundreds of years, this was a shocking first.

Then, in the next moment, the Water God Dragon realized something.

The human who had ripped out its whiskers through sheer physical strength was completely fucking insane.

“Baldy!”

Pop!

“Baldy!”

Pop-pop!

“Smooth, shiny baldy!”

Pop-pop-pop-pop-pop!

—Gwooooooooooar!

A scream rose from the depths of its soul.

The Mutated Water God Dragon thrashed and howled in agony. For some inexplicable reason, the pain and sorrow surging through it were dozens of times worse than when it had first lost its eye.

It had to get this mad human off it as quickly as possible.

No—before every last whisker was torn out, it had to save at least one!

—Kroaaaaaah!

But despite the Water God Dragon’s desperate wish, Jin Taekyung had no intention of stopping.

Puhuk!

Jin Taekyung drove the spearhead between the scales covering the bridge of its nose, anchoring himself in place, and spoke in a sinister voice.

“Hey, know why you can’t walk?”

—Krrk…?

“Because you don’t have two feet.”

Pop-pop-pop-pop-pop!

—Gwooooooar!

"Multiply the number of hairs on every spiritual creature in the world together and you still get zero. Because you don't have any hair. You just don't. You don't have a single goddamn hair!"

Kwadeudeudeuk!

Jin Taekyung's methods were more ruthless than ever.

Whenever the whiskers flew at him in a tangled mass, he caught them with one hand and yanked them out like weeds. Iron-hard skin split open, and the whiskers —tougher and sharper than Heavenly Silkworm Thread—were ripped out by the roots.

Every last one of them. Not a single strand remained.

—Uooh, uwooooooar!

Even through its reason, now as murky as a sky smothered by storm clouds, the Mutated Water God Dragon was consumed by overwhelming rage and sorrow.

What kind of whiskers were these?

Those whiskers had grown alongside it for hundreds of years. They were companions to its very soul.

They were excellent weapons for destroying intruders who harbored impudent thoughts, and symbols of its power and majesty.

And now they were gone. They had been pulled out as helplessly as weak, useless seaweed.

By the hands of a human far smaller and more insignificant than itself!

—Kyaaaaaaaaaow!

A savage roar shook heaven and earth.

As the master that had ruled Dongting Lake and the Yangtze for hundreds of years radiated its baleful presence, everything around it held its breath.

No. Everything changed in response to its fury.

Krrrrrung! Kwa-gwang!

It was a truly frightening and bizarre sight. Lightning struck without pause from a sky shrouded in unusually thick black clouds, while rain poured down in a deluge unlike anything seen in the past fifty years.

Swollen several times over by the abnormal weather of the past several shichen,[2247] the river formed whirlpools large and small that circled the Water God Dragon.

Kwaaaaaaaaa!

And in the middle of that landscape, which resembled a minor catastrophe, stood an enormous body towering like a steel tower.

At the sight of the monster, its eye glowing bloodred, the people on the ground groaned quietly.

[2247] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"Good heavens."

"Damn it. This old man really has lived a long time. I never thought I'd see something so absurd."

Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong stared at the unbelievable scene in astonishment.

They had long known that beings called spiritual creatures and evil creatures possessed astonishing power, but what was unfolding before them lay far beyond anything they had imagined.

A monster as large as a small mountain.

When it swung its tail, cliffs collapsed. When it roared, the world shook in every direction.

And that was not all. Mountains, rivers, plants, and trees held their breath beneath its surging baleful presence, while lightning and water responded to its fury.

Something that belonged in an old, faded legend was happening in reality.

At that moment, a single thought arose in the minds of the two old masters.

Supernatural powers.

Things of the strange, prodigious force, rebellion, and ghosts.

Everything embodied by that four-character phrase was unfolding before them.

An inexplicable being and phenomena beyond the understanding of even two men who had spent long years in the Murim were appearing before their eyes.

But the words *supernatural powers* did not belong to only one being.

Kwadeuk!

The sound of flesh tearing rang out clearly even amid the thunder and lightning.

The next moment, scales drenched in dark-blue blood poured down over Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong's heads.

One, two, three…

Soon, dozens of scales pattered down like a sudden shower.

With eyesight like birds of prey, the two men saw what was happening high above and were rendered speechless.

"Flesh! Let's see the flesh underneath!"

"…!"

"…!"

Kwadeudeudeuk!

A young man shouted like a lunatic as his hands moved furiously.

One hand gripped the shaft of his spear with all his strength. The other held no weapon at all as his bare fingers seized a scale.

Then he yanked hard.

The scale tore free helplessly, trailing dark-blue blood.

—Kwooooooooar!

The Mutated Water God Dragon thrashed its enormous body and let out a savage cry, but it was useless.

Whenever Jin Taekyung caught a hint of an attack, he darted like a ghost into the gaping hollow where its eye had melted away. Once the monster's rampage ended, he popped his head back out and resumed his work.

He even threw in a few furious punches for good measure.

"You fucking bastard!"

Kwaang! Kwang! Kwajijik!

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, one of the five most destructive techniques among the Fire Gate Clan's various secret arts, combined with strength tremendous enough to call him superhuman.

The monster's head, nearly the size of an average ship, shook violently as shattered scales rained down.

—Kyaaaaaaaaaow!

The Mutated Water God Dragon was at its wits' end.

When it still had its whiskers, it had at least been able to attack.

But now that every last one had been pulled out, it had no idea what to do.

Whenever it thrashed to throw him off, he held on with the spear driven into its flesh. Whenever it seemed to calm down, he emerged and tore off more scales.

What the hell was it supposed to do?

Perhaps because it had smashed its head against the cliff so many times, it was even beginning to feel dizzy.

Kwaang! Kwaaaaaang!

Mungyeong and Jeok Cheongang could only open and close their mouths as they watched.

This fucking lunatic…

What is he doing? It's not like he's pulling radishes out of the ground…

Both men knew just how durable those scales were, which only made the sight more astonishing.

The crude Sword Energy of someone who had only just entered the Peak realm could barely cut them. Only Force could reliably split the scales and damage what lay beneath.

Those bizarre scales were absurdly hard.

And yet that young whelp had simply smashed them apart and ripped them off.

With nothing but his bare hands.

Did he draw up every last bit of his internal energy? Even so, a human's physical strength should be nowhere near enough.

What in the… No, wait. That bastard could do it.

Mungyeong felt as though he were dreaming.

Jeok Cheongang, who had watched Jin Taekyung ever since Shanxi Province, found the whole thing absurd—and astonishing.

"What a goddamn lunatic! Hahahaha!"

It was not enough that Jin Taekyung had torn out every whisker, one of the monster's weapons. Now he had begun stripping away its scales as well.

For a martial artist, it was like breaking all their weapons and stripping away the armor worn over their martial uniform.

From Jeok Cheongang's perspective, Jin Taekyung's current insight into martial arts was clearly inferior to that of both old masters—and even below Cheongpung's.

But his very foundation was different.

He's simply strong.

As a martial artist, Jin Taekyung was a powerful fighter who had reached the Supreme Peak realm.

Yet even if the internal energy and martial insight he had accumulated over several jiazi[2248] vanished, he would still be strong in his own right.

It was as though the power of heaven had taken residence in a human body made of mere flesh.

"Is that truly possible?"

Faint astonishment colored Mungyeong's voice.

Jeok Cheongang laughed with delight.

It was a question he had asked himself countless times while training in the Fire Gate Cavern. And every time, Jin Taekyung had responded with an infuriatingly shameless answer.

Now it was time to pass that answer on to someone else.

"Yeah. Heavenly Martial Physique."

"…!"

"Absurd, isn't it? Good. Don't bother trying to understand. That bastard has always been like that."

Just as Jeok Cheongang shrugged, Cheongpung spoke with a determined expression.

"Come on, let's go too. Mimi! Strike with lightning! Whip up a whirlwind![2249]"

…Chirik, chiriririk?

"Oh. You can't."

"…That idiot's no different."

[2248] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[2249] Calling out a creature's attacks by name this way imitates a Pokémon trainer commanding a Pokémon in battle.

Just as Jeok Cheongang threatened to make Cheongpung drink liquor made from a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake if he spouted one more load of bullshit, an eerie silence and oppressive presence bore down upon everything within a radius of several dozen *jang*.[2250]

Gugugugugung!

Jeok Cheongang, Mungyeong, and Cheongpung felt a chill run down their spines and raised their heads.

Gooooooooong.

The air rippled.

By then, the wind and rain that had been pouring down without pause had stopped.

So did the lightning.

Everything held its breath.

Everyone on the ground saw the monster's bloodred pupil, which had been shedding a crimson aura, slowly turn pitch-black.

At the same time, its enormous maw slowly opened, revealing cavernous darkness, while a sphere of water churned as though being sucked into its depths.

What is that?

A single question flashed through everyone's mind.

Then a shout came from high above.

No—a scream.

"Get out of the way—!"

Before they could even realize that the voice belonged to Jin Taekyung, the three figures shot away like the wind.

Though there were differences between them, great and small, each was a Supreme Peak master and an experienced martial artist with exceptional combat instincts.

They could not discern the true nature of that thing, but they could tell how terrifying the unknown power within it was.

Their prediction proved exactly right.

Kwaaaaaaaaa—!

With a deafening roar, the enormous sphere of water shot toward the ground.

There are many different kinds of monsters.

[2250] A *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Some are bipedal, with bodies resembling humans. Others are beast-type monsters that walk and run on four legs like animals, yet are hundreds of times stronger than those bipedal monsters.

Their Intelligence varies just as widely from species to species.

Some are simple-minded brutes, but their insane physical abilities have earned them a place among the higher-level monsters.

Others, like goblins, hunt in packs and employ tactics involving poison and ambushes, but are classified among the lowest-level monsters because of their poor physical abilities.

With monsters possessing such diverse traits, arguments are inevitable whenever the subject comes up—both among actual experts and every fucking know-it-all on the internet.

Even so, when people talk about the strongest monsters, there is one type that everyone names first.

Dragonkin.

Beings blessed with extraordinary Intelligence and physiques.

And the mighty power granted exclusively to them.

Breath.

But why on earth?

Why?

Why?

Kwaaaaaaaaaah!

…Why the hell was this bastard using Breath?

Chapter 475

The Mutated Water God Dragon.

When you got right down to it, this bastard was a dragon too.

It might have been closer to an *imugi*[2251] than a true dragon, considering it could neither roam beneath the azure heavens nor wield a dragon pearl.[2252]

But there was one problem…

This bastard with its murky identity knew how to use Breath.

And not just any Breath. A fucking powerful one.

Kwaaaaaaaaaah!

I stared with my mouth hanging open as an enormous sphere of water spread across a radius of several dozen *jang*.[2253]

The ground, built up layer upon layer over centuries by sediment flowing from the Yangtze, collapsed by nearly half in an instant.

This is insane.

A force far beyond ordinary water pressure.

That was not merely an enormous quantity of water gathered together and fired all at once.

With the Mutated Water God Dragon's immense qi infused into the sphere, it was only right to call it Water Breath from now on.

Water Breath in the Murim.

It would have been more natural if some insane undead monster had insisted it was from Atlanta, Georgia, in the United States.

I stared in horror as the Water Breath vomited by the Water God Dragon pulverized everything in its path.

At the same moment, three figures shot away from the ground being reduced to a wasteland.

"Mimi, blow up the water orb![2254]"

"…You're completely insane. I felt murderous intent for a moment there without even realizing it."

"That's normal. This old man has wanted to kill you about five times already."

One lunatic pestering a horned snake. One rejuvenated old man. And one old man who could hardly look any older.

Once I confirmed that all three were safe, a sigh of relief escaped me.

[2251] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with dragons.

[2252] A dragon pearl is a legendary orb associated with dragons in East Asian folklore.

[2253] One *jang* is about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 150 meters (500 ft).

[2254] Calling out a creature's attack by name this way imitates a Pokémon trainer commanding a Pokémon in battle.

Thank goodness they dodged it.

If they took a direct hit from Breath with that level of destructive power, even a Supreme Peak master could not escape unharmed.

The Water Breath fired by the Mutated Water God Dragon was that powerful. It contained qi that far surpassed the Breath of the Black Wyvern I had personally killed in the past.

What the hell? It was strong before, but I don't remember it being this strong…

Was it the effect of Berserk? Or had it only now drawn out all the power lying dormant within it?

I did not know the exact cause, but it unquestionably had something to do with its pupil suddenly turning black.

And my goal right now was to bring this bastard down by any means necessary.

—Krrrrrrk.

Its pitch-black pupil gleamed.

The monster let out a low growl at the humans who had dodged its attack with the speed of a streak of light, then opened its maw again.

Gooooooong.

Along with an immense flow of qi, the waterspouts circling it surged upward as though being sucked into its gaping jaws.

Already…?

A second Water Breath.

Even wyverns, the modern world's quintessential dragonkin monsters, could not use Breath this quickly or this frequently.

This thing was on an entirely different level.

Before the Water Breath could be completed, I swung with all my strength and slammed my fist into the bridge of its nose as its jaws slowly opened.

"You gaping bastard!"

Kwaang!

The enormous head shook with a deafening boom.

The sudden jolt made the rapidly forming sphere of water falter. But despite accomplishing what I had intended, my expression hardened.

It's different.

That punch had carried all my strength.

Yet the resistance I felt through my fist was nothing like it had been only moments earlier.

Breath was not the only change that had occurred in the Mutated Water God Dragon. Its body had grown stronger as well.

To put it simply, it felt as if a punch that should have smashed through ten pine boards had stopped after breaking only five.

I clenched my teeth.

Damn it.

I should have adapted my approach to the situation, but I had been too complacent. I grabbed White Flame, which I had shoved between the dragon's scales.

Store in Inventory. Open. Summon.

Shhk!

In the blink of an eye, White Flame vanished as though dissolving into empty space, passed through my Inventory, and reappeared in my grasp.

Every movement had been pared down to the absolute minimum. It was something impossible without the System, and even I had only recently begun to master this application.

The moment White Flame's shaft settled into my hand, all my preparations were already complete, and I brought it down in a single strike.

Fwoosh!

Blue-white flames rose over the transparent spearhead, burning the air and evaporating the moisture filling the surroundings.

The flames sliced through the dense, foglike steam toward the black-scaled bridge of the monster's nose.

"Shut your mouth."

Heavenly Strike.

Kwaaaaaaaaaah—schk!

The immense flames summoned by burning internal energy split the scales. They burned through flesh and shattered bone.

Even flesh of astonishing toughness could not stop a strike that fused Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron with Force.

Behind everything cleaved apart to either side of the spearhead was the nearly completed sphere of water.

Cut.

The centuries-old Water God Dragon's Water Breath met the fire dragon's claw plunging down like a lightning bolt from the heavens.

No.

They collided head-on.

Goooooooong—

Along with a deafening boom that numbed my ears, red and blue flashes filled my vision.

That day, those present at the scene were not the only ones who heard the mysterious roar.

Everyone staying near Dongting Lake heard it.

Gugugugugung!

Mountains, rivers, and trees bowed beneath a tremendous boom unlike any peal of thunder.

Commoners who had shut themselves indoors to avoid the ominous atmosphere flung themselves facedown in shock, while government troops roaming near Dongting Lake to investigate the incident dropped their spears and fled in terror.

Elderly men patted their sobbing grandchildren and gazed worriedly at the sky as they muttered,

“It’s the divine spirit. The divine spirit has grown angry and brought heavenly punishment down upon someone. What is going to become of this wretched world…?”

They were half right and half wrong.

The divine being passed down by word of mouth for hundreds of years, from the distant past to the present day, had indeed existed.

But the spirit beast once worshiped as a divine spirit had degenerated into a hideous evil beast, and the heavenly punishment delivered by the enraged Mutated Water God Dragon had been blocked by a single human.

Deep in a part of Dongting Lake that no one ever visited, the battle between that human and the evil beast continued even now.

—Kroaaaaaaaaah!

A pained roar shook heaven and earth in every direction.

The monster, its maw torn open, writhed and threw its body onto the waters of Dongting Lake.

Kwa-gwa-gwa-gwa!

The river water, mixed with dark-blue blood, surged to a distant height in an instant.

Waves fit for the distant open sea rose and crashed in every direction. Three figures no larger than specks beside the monster’s enormous body darted just ahead of them.

Shweeeeeek!

Three figures shot through the air like arrows.

But one of them chose a direction completely opposite to the other two.

Seeing Jeok Cheongang charge alone toward the monster instead of dodging, Mungyeong sent a Sound Transmission.

“Fire King!”

But rather than answer, Jeok Cheongang thrust one palm toward the oncoming wave.

Poom!

With a heavy crack of displaced air, a hole burst through the center of the enormous wave about to swallow his small, aged body, and the water evaporated into steam.

A second and third wave soon came rolling in, driven by the monster's ceaseless, pain-filled thrashing.

But the next moment, they were cleanly sliced apart.

Shraak!

A pure-white streak of light had severed the waves through their middles.

Then Cheongpung's scattered Sword Energy mingled with the spray and reduced the pebbles flying through it to dust. Mungyeong shook the water from his short sword and spoke to Jeok Cheongang.

"There are a few things I want to ask. Did you happen to learn water arts since we last saw each other?"

Jeok Cheongang glanced at Mungyeong and answered bluntly.

"Do you know what this old man hates most in the world?"

"…?"

"First, getting wet. Second, setting a mountain on fire. And third—the last one—watching a mountain burn while I'm soaking wet. Those three things."

"What does that have to do with—"

"It was about fifty years ago. I'd just finished taking a bath I didn't want in a nearby valley, and when I came out, Mount Jiuhua was going up in flames. In the end, I hunted down and killed every last one of those sons of bitches."

It was a story every martial artist knew.

After that day, an old man who had been practicing martial arts deep in the mountains of Mount Jiuhua gained the name Fire King.

"Well, things worked out well enough, and the people around me started praising me as the Fire King and whatnot. But some insane bastards pointed fingers behind my back. They called me a Killing Ghost of an old man who could kill a thousand people without batting an eye."

Mungyeong frowned at Jeok Cheongang's attitude. The old man was not even looking at him, simply saying whatever he pleased.

"I have no idea what you're talking about. What kind of nonsense is—"

"It's nothing. To put it simply, this old man liked Mount Jiuhua. I liked it even more because it was the first home I could call my own. During the Great Faction War, I drilled it into every bastard under heaven that I'd crush anyone who touched what belonged to me, no matter what it took. But…"

Jeok Cheongang walked toward the writhing monster, his eyes blazing as he continued,

“That damned bastard doesn’t seem to know that. Then again, if it had known, it wouldn’t have touched my Disciple without a shred of fear.”

“You really do whatever you please. So after all that, you never learned water arts.”

“Damn it. We’ll manage somehow.”

“We’re hardly friends, but even I feel compelled to tell you to be careful.”

“Do water arts really matter when dealing with one lousy eel? I’ll hunt it down and crush it by any means necessary.”

Cheongpung joined in with an innocent voice.

“Wow. Do eels really get that big? Are they all about fifty *jang*[2255] long?”

“I feel the urge to kill rising.”

“If you’re going to kill him, ask the Sword Saint for permission and do it quietly. Of course, lend us a hand first.”

Mungyeong lightly adjusted his grip on his short sword, then suddenly spoke.

“Did Jin Taekyung happen to learn water arts?”

“I vividly remember training him in the deep valleys of Mount Jiuhua. I’ve never seen anyone so bad at swimming in my life.”

“…Then we’ll have to drag that monster onto land immediately.”

“I agree. I don’t want to lose my Disciple twice.”

If the battle took place underwater, it went without saying that the Water God Dragon would have the advantage.

But there was no other choice.

If they did not step in, Jin Taekyung would drown.

Just as Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong exchanged determined looks, Cheongpung suddenly spoke.

“Huh? That’s not right. Benefactor is really good at swimming.”

“…?”

“…?”

“It’s true. On the way here, Benefactor… Uh, what was it again? Oh, right. He asked me to call him Aguaman.”[2256]

What the hell was that supposed to mean?

The two old masters stopped short, confusion rising in their eyes.

At that very moment—

—Gwooooooooar!

[2255] One *jang* is about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 150 meters (500 ft).

[2256] Aguaman is Cheongpung’s mistaken version of Aquaman, a superhero associated with the sea.

Shraaaaaaaaah!

Along with a roar echoing from deep beneath the river, a human figure shot up through the surface.

Jeok Cheongang's jaw dropped when he recognized the familiar face amid the spray exploding in every direction.

"You, you…"

"Pwah! Form up!"

"W-What did you say?"

There was no time to resolve his confusion.

The instant the words left his mouth, a huge shadow rippled across the rolling surface.

At the same time, a thunderous shout burst from Jin Taekyung's lips as he landed on the ground.

"Form an attack formation!"

What burned in his eyes was not the look of a martial artist.

It was the look of a seasoned Hunter.

Chapter 476

When was it?

I once saw a line like that in an old wuxia[2257] film whose title I no longer remember.

“Martial arts are only vertical and horizontal. In the end, one of us falls and the other remains standing.”

It was true. The countless battles I had fought in Murim had always ended in one of two ways.

Either I knocked them down, or they knocked me down.

Except for the Blood Lord, who had escaped even after losing an arm, the outcome had always been one or the other—and it had never been me who fell.

But when I plunged into the deep river while clinging to the Mutated Water God Dragon, I remembered another possibility I had briefly forgotten.

What if this bastard runs?

He had effectively been the master of Dongting Lake and the Yangtze for hundreds of years.

They said even a mutt had half the battle won in its own yard. If the bastard decided to run, there was no way I could stop him.

At the same time, I realized that I had been laboring under a serious misconception.

This shouldn’t have been a battle. It should have been a hunt.

This was not a life-and-death duel between two martial artists.

To bring down the monster before me, I had to do whatever it took, by any means necessary.

I had lived as a Hunter for seven solid years, yet without realizing it, I had been pretending to be some hidebound martial artist. I couldn’t help laughing quietly at myself.

What a stupid thing to do.

Hunter and martial artist. Martial artist and Hunter.

Both were part of my identity. I was the one and only modern martial artist—and Murim’s Hunter.

Standing once more on the blurred boundary between them, a line that had nearly faded away, I reminded myself of that fact.

That’s right. This is it.

It felt as though I had awakened from a very long sleep. I landed lightly on the shore and let out a thunderous shout.

[2257] Wuxia is a genre of Chinese fiction and film about martial artists and their adventures.

“Form an attack formation!”

“…!”

“…!”

“…!”

The flow of the air changed in an instant, and three pairs of eyes widened. Of the three, Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong stared at me with trembling eyes before speaking.

“I coddle you a little, and now a greenhorn still wet behind the ears dares speak casually to this old man?”

“The Fire King made a complete mess of training his Disciple.”

“…I apologize. It slipped out.”

I’d forgotten who was standing here.

I must have lost my head after getting swept up in the moment.

Unlike the two old men glaring at me with their eyes blazing, Cheongpung responded enthusiastically.

“Benefactor, that was so cool! Mimi! Form an attack formation!”

Chirik!

“I swear to heaven and earth that one day, I will turn that snake bastard into liquor—”

Jeok Cheongang’s oath never reached its conclusion.

The enormous shadow wavering across the rolling surface finally burst through the water and revealed itself.

—Kroaaaaaaaaah!

A roar more savage than any before shook heaven and earth.

Overwhelming qi exploded from its body, as large as a small mountain, and bore down on everything around it. The air trembled beneath the Fear it released.

At the center of it all, dozens of *jang*[2258] above us in the distant sky, was a pitch-black pupil looking down at us.

When that single eye, formed from darkness without even a speck of light, gleamed, a groan escaped someone’s lips.

“Ugh…!”

Fear of the unknown.

Everyone except Cheongpung and me remained at least partly vulnerable to the Fear emitted by the Mutated Water God Dragon.

Even Supreme Peak masters counted among the greatest in the world were no exception.

But…

[2258] A *jang* is a traditional length unit equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft. Thirty *jang* is about 90.9 m or 298 ft.

I'm here.

I was a veteran Hunter who had fought monsters until I was sick of them. That was who I was.

I had stood my ground against an undead army numbering in the tens of thousands, rotten flesh dangling from their bodies as they charged. I had no reason to tremble in fear just because one eel the size of an aircraft carrier had joined the fight.

"Now that I look at you again, you're practically a fairy."

The words had barely left my mouth before the back of my head began to prickle. From the listener's perspective, it probably sounded like complete madness.

But what I had just said was one hundred percent sincere.

It's true that this bastard is powerful, but the Arch Lich was much harder to deal with—and much stronger.

If the Skeleton King hadn't helped me back then, I would have died without question.

But the important thing was that I had survived and brought the bastard down. The fear I had felt while facing the Arch Lich had become experience, carved into my body and mind in its entirety.

And I'm a fast learner.

Good or bad, every experience became part of me. Over the past seven years, I had learned how to survive and how to win.

I drew a deep breath and raised White Flame's shaft high into the air.

Then I slammed the end down with all my strength. A level of internal energy never seen before rode the shaft.

Gooooooong!

The wave of qi that shot outward with the deafening boom pushed back the Fear radiating from the dragon.

The crushing pressure that had completely surrounded us dissipated as though an invisible pane of glass had shattered.

"This is…"

"You…"

Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong stared at me in astonishment. I kept my eyes fixed on the dragon and spoke.

"First. Don't get scared for no reason."

"…!"

"…!"

Everyone carried fears, great and small, inside their hearts. Fear was a force that preyed upon those fears and turned them into terror.

But once that fear was stripped away, we could finally recognize something we had forgotten.

—Krrrrrrrr.

The enormous monster letting out that low growl was not as powerful or frightening as we had imagined.

I stared straight into its gleaming, pitch-black pupil and continued.

“Second. From this point on, follow my instructions and beat the shit out of that bastard without mercy.”

Mungyeong’s dry voice pierced my ears.

“I do not particularly care for the process, but the result sounds rather pleasant.”

“You don’t dislike it because of that, do you?”

“What do you take me for?”

“That was a stupid question.”

The Slaughter Saint.

The greatest assassin, past or present, in Murim’s long history.

To an assassin who eliminated a target by any means necessary, the process did not matter. Only the result did.

“Old Master.”

“As far as this old man remembers, I never taught you how to deal with an evil beast like that… We can discuss it after we finish the bastard off.”

Tssssss!

After Jeok Cheongang’s curt reply, Cheongpung answered with purple Sword Force instead of words.

It was a nightmare of a party composition: nothing but DPS, without a healer or a tank. Even so, there could not have been a more powerful raid team.

Four Supreme Peak masters.

A lineup impressive enough to make even a five-star Jangsu stone bed weep.[2259]

Compared to the enormous body of the Mutated Water God Dragon, we were no more than ants. But inside each of us crouched a giant carrying an unprecedented power.

And now, the four giants were going to hunt a colossal monster.

“You’re dead now.”

As if it understood me, the Mutated Water God Dragon raised its enormous body from beneath the surface and roared.

—Gwooooooooooar!

Krrrrung, kwaaaaaaaaaang!

[2259] Jangsu is a Korean stone-bed brand whose advertising is associated with the phrase “five stars.”

With a single roar, dozens of waterspouts rose and came crashing toward us. Between them, the dragon's ragged maw split wide.

Gooooooooong—!

The air vibrated faster and more powerfully than before.

But before the third Water Breath could take shape, a shout burst from my lips and pierced the wind and rain to reach everyone's ears.

"Spread out!"

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish!

As though following a prearranged signal, four figures shot away in different directions and took positions around the dragon.

At last, it was time for the hunt.

Raid.

When the unreal invaded reality and Hunters and monsters began fighting one another to the death, this word—once used only in fantasy games—became something even a three-year-old child knew.

But none of the billions of people who had survived the Great Cataclysm could have imagined that another raid was taking place somewhere beyond time and space, against a strange monster resembling a dragon.

Nor could they have imagined that a familiar face was caught up at the center of it all.

Tat-tat, shweeeeeek!

A solidly built figure bounded off fragments of flying rock and shot skyward.

A massive tail passed within a hair's breadth, smashing into a half-collapsed cliff and unleashing a blast of wind.

Through his streaming hair, the eyes of the young man—Jin Taekyung—gleamed.

If I cut that tail now… No. Don't.

Jin Taekyung restrained the hand that instinctively wanted to swing his spear.

He knew exactly what mattered most in this raid.

He had to block the Mutated Water God Dragon's escape, lure it as far onto land as possible, and dispatch it in a flash.

If he struck back and wounded it before then, he might only put the monster on guard.

Of course, someone watching the scene had a slightly different opinion.

"You fucking piece of—!"

I can't lose the Disciple I only managed to gain in my old age like this!

But Jeok Cheongang's movement as he prepared to launch a palm strike at the monster, accompanied by a thick curse, abruptly stopped at the shout that rang out the next moment.

"Old Master!"

"…!"

Fwoosh, kwaaaaaaaaaang!

The Scorching Yang Qi hastily veered aside and burned the innocent ground.

For the briefest instant, puzzlement passed through the dragon's pitch-black eye. Then it changed into the eye of a savage beast.

—Gwooooooooar!

Whoom, bang!

With a roar, its enormous tail swept across the ground like a broom.

Jeok Cheongang leaped into the air at the last instant to evade the attack and exploded in frustration.

"How long are you planning to make us retreat!"

Kwaang!

Far above the ground, Jin Taekyung dodged the monster's body as it came crashing toward him and answered.

"I told you I'd give the signal!"

"And when is that going to be?"

"I'll handle it when the time comes, so please stop shitting all over the place! There's only so much trolling I can take! Do what you're told like everyone else!"

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes trembled.

Some of the strange words prevented him from understanding exactly what Taekyung meant, but he had heard one thing perfectly clearly.

A dump? This old man is taking a dump?

Until recently, he had been worried that his infirmities of old age might progress to the point where he started smearing feces on the walls. Now the boy he considered his Disciple was saying something that vile to him.

The shout that followed jolted Jeok Cheongang out of his shock.

"Old Master, now! Fall back thirty *jang*[2260]! Cheongpung, move behind the bastard! Mungyeong, take the flank!"

"Yes, Benefactor!"

"What a strange fellow. I agreed to follow your lead, not to let you speak casually to me."

[2260] A *jang* is a traditional length unit equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft. Thirty *jang* is about 90.9 m or 298 ft.

“For fuck’s sake, I really can’t stand ranged-DPS assholes who refuse to communicate. Just listen to me!”

“…!”

Seeing Mungyeong struck speechless, clamp his mouth shut, and silently do as he was told improved Jeok Cheongang’s mood slightly.

At least he calls me Old Master.

He should have been angry. But seeing Mungyeong addressed by his bare name like some nobody from next door made Jeok Cheongang grateful that Taekyung had not simply called him Cheongang.

At the same time, he thought he understood Mungyeong’s feelings as he moved without another word.

What is this strange feeling?

How should he put it?

Jin Taekyung was radiating an almost absurd air of command.

And in Jeok Cheongang’s estimation, it was not the overwhelming presence or bearing of a Supreme Peak master.

It was more like…

A veteran. Yes, exactly. A battle-hardened veteran.

Jeok Cheongang had lived his entire life as a martial artist. He had never had any connection to the authorities, nor had he ever been a soldier.

Yet for some reason, he felt as though he understood what it was like for a fresh recruit on the battlefield to stand before a battle-hardened veteran.

“What an incredibly strange fellow, no matter how many times I look at him…”

“Hey, Jeok Cheongang! Snap out of it!”

“…!”

The corner of Jeok Cheongang’s eye twitched. But before he could unleash his anger, the words he had been waiting for finally rang out.

“Now—strike!”

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish!

The four giants shot forward at the same time toward the Water God Dragon, which had finally left the waters of Dongting Lake and climbed onto land.

Chapter 477

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish!

Front, back, left, right.

The instant the Mutated Water God Dragon noticed four figures shooting toward it from every direction, its one remaining eye widened.

—Krrk!

When did they…?

Even in Berserk Status, the Mutated Water God Dragon could tell the situation was turning against it.

But rage had paralyzed its reason, and the immense power contained within its large, beautiful body led the strange and terrifying evil beast to underestimate its opponents.

Then someone shouted.

That was enough to sever the last thread of reason that had barely registered the danger.

“Even if everyone else curses you, I believe you’re a good guy. Because you don’t have a single rough edge.”

—Krrrrrr…!

A murderous light flashed in its pupil, which was nearly as large as a grown man.

It did not matter what that tiny, insignificant human was babbling about.

All that mattered was that he was the one who had ripped out every last whisker—the dragon’s pride, its finest weapon, and practically its soulmate for hundreds of years.

Kill him.

No matter what it takes, I will kill that fucking human!

Whooooooosh!

Its enormous tail, filled with murderous intent, blasted apart everything in its path.

At the end of that path, one man’s lips curled into a faint smile.

“Got you, you son of a bitch.”

What?

A chill swept through the Mutated Water God Dragon’s entire body, but it was already too late.

With that much force and speed behind it, pulling its tail back was as impossible as recalling an arrow after it had been fired.

Whoom, boom!

Everything was crushed beneath the violently swinging tail.

The cliff that had barely been holding together collapsed completely, and the resulting roar swallowed every other sound.

But what awaited the Mutated Water God Dragon was not the thrill of crushing its enemy.

It was searing pain.

Fwoosh, thk!

No.

It was not imagining things.

The next moment, the Mutated Water God Dragon saw it clearly.

Through the slowly dispersing wind, rain, and clouds of dust, a spear wreathed in blue-white flames had pierced straight through its large, beautiful tail.

And the fucking human gripping that spear was smiling.

“Got you.”

—…!

My mother had always been lenient when it came to raising her children.

She never believed studying was the only path to success. Even when she saw my high school report card—sevens in every subject,[2261] like I’d hit the slot-machine jackpot—she ended her lecture with one short remark.

“Amazing, my son…”

Hmm. Now that I thought about it, she may already have given up on me halfway by then.

In any case, even she made me read books when I was young.

I think it was in elementary school. She saw me folding paper airplanes out of an English workbook and flying them around, so she handed me a book and told me to read that instead.

The title was…

Oh, right.

Gulliver’s Travels.

Even though I had no talent for studying, I enjoyed novels like that. Sometimes, I even reenacted memorable scenes from them with Hayeon.

For example, the scene where the Lilliputians tied Gulliver down with ropes.

“Mom! Look! I caught Hayeon! She’ll be quiet now!”

“Waaaaaah! Mommy!”

“No! Hayeon! My daughter!”

Of course, my curiosity did not end particularly well.

[2261] South Korean high school grades used a nine-band scale, with 1 the highest and 9 the lowest.

When my mother saw her young daughter bound from head to toe in blue packing tape, she screamed. Then she used a *hyojason*[2262] to beat the calves of the son who had just proven himself decidedly unfilial.

But with a tenacity unusual for an elementary schooler, I did not shed a single tear.

I did, however, reflect on where I had gone wrong.

“Next time, I need to tape her mouth shut too, so she can’t scream!”

Ah, what fond memories.

The vicious elementary schooler who had bound his much younger sister in blue packing tape was long gone, but the memory of that day remained vivid.

Along with the ambition I had held as a child: to tie up Gulliver just like in the novel.

Thk!

That’s right.

Just like now.

Remembering the childhood dream I had thought would never come true, I spoke.

“Got you.”

—…!

My method was more brutal than the one the Lilliputians had used on Gulliver, but it was undeniably effective.

I had predicted that the bastard would swing its tail. I dodged just before the enormous, hideous thing lashed across my body, then drove my spearhead in with all my strength.

White Flame, the sturdy, transparent divine weapon, became a massive nail that pierced through both the monster’s tail and the ground beneath it.

What about a hammer?

Obviously, that would be my fist.

And I still had plenty of nails left.

Open Inventory. Summon.

Thk-thk-thk-thk-thk!

It all happened in an instant.

I summoned five spears from my Inventory in a flash and drove them into the bastard’s tail. Then I brought my fist down in place of a hammer.

Boom! Boom! Booooom!

Anchoring complete.

My powerful punch struck the ends of the spear shafts. The sharp spearheads sank deep into the ground and trembled.

Hayeon, are you watching?

[2262] A Korean back scratcher whose name literally means “filial son’s hand.”

I trembled with satisfaction at the sight.

The Mutated Water God Dragon screamed in agony.

—Gwooooooooar!

But its scream seemed a little premature to me.

Three people who had been waiting for this exact moment were just about to unleash attacks with everything they had.

The fastest among them arrived first and swung his sword at the dragon's waist.

Shk—!

Ghostlike movement.

Speed too great for even my eyes to follow completely.

Nothing could stop the dazzling flash that burst from that gray-white shadow.

Not even scales hardened further by Berserk Status.

Not even flesh and bone as tough as iron.

It was none other than the Slaughter Saint's sword strike.

Shrrk!

A clear sound of cutting pierced through the confusion of battle and reached my ears.

Mungyeong's figure, having dealt a devastating blow with the fastest and most concise sword strike in existence, vanished in a blur.

Dark blood erupted like a waterfall, and a scream of agony burst from the monster's maw.

—Kuaaaargh!

The attack had not severed its torso completely, but a single strike had sliced through nearly one-fifth of its thickness.

Of course it screamed.

But there was one thing I wanted the bastard to know.

This was not over yet.

"Two more strikes."

Before I had even finished speaking, purple Force resembling the glow of sunset shot forward and lit the darkness.

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish!

Dozens of red plum blossoms appeared amid the swirling wind and rain.

That was no illusion.

I instantly recognized the trails drawn by the purple Force infused with the Zaha Divine Technique, known as the essence of Huashan.

The Plum Blossom Sword Technique.

If Mungyeong's sword was a razor-sharp guillotine that severed its target in a single blow, Cheongpung's Plum Blossom Sword Technique was a dagger that slashed and carved dozens of times.

Now that dagger had taken the shape of plum blossoms and was plunging into the split wound.

Thk-thk-thk! Shrrk!

Bringing down an enormous opponent was surprisingly simple.

Either hit it with one tremendous blow powerful enough to knock it flat, or keep pounding the same spot.

And make it hurt like hell.

Before the Mutated Water God Dragon could unleash yet another scream, someone came rushing in to deliver a blow that combined both methods.

"Can't you just fucking die, you motherless evil-beast bastard!"

A streak of flame tore across the battlefield, accompanied by a filthy insult about the bastard's parents that was wildly unbecoming of his age.

The Fire King.

The illegal resident of Mount Jiuhua.

The firebug of the Great Faction War.

A national-level thug who had dominated the Murim with seniority as insane as Bodhidharma's skull water[2263] and martial arts even more explosive.

Just looking at him made my heart race and my eyes burn.

Ah, fuck it.

Whatever happens, happens. I'd already dropped the formalities anyway.

Once you were riding a tiger, there was nothing left to be afraid of.

Feeling my blood boil, I shouted at the top of my lungs.

"Go, Fire King! Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist!"

"You fucking little—!"

I could not tell who he was cursing, because the enormous boom that followed drowned him out.

Fwoosh, kwaaaaaaang!

Flames erupted from his fist and shot forward, vaporizing every trace of moisture in their path.

Hellfire carrying unimaginable heat tore into the gaping wound created by the previous two attacks, burning and devouring everything inside.

—Kraaaaaaaaaah!

I remembered hearing somewhere that death by fire was the most painful death in the world.

[2263] An allusion to a Korean Buddhist tale usually told about the monk Wonhyo, who drank water in the dark and later discovered it had come from a skull.

Anyone who saw this scene would have no choice but to agree completely.

Heat filled the air on every side, hot enough to conjure visions of a fiery hell, along with the thick, acrid stench of burning flesh.

And in the middle of it all, a gigantic monster writhed, engulfed in hellfire.

—…!

A terrible scream unlike anything we had heard before shook the ground and drove back the waters of Dongting Lake.

Its agony made it thrash so violently that even I, gripping the embedded spears with all my strength, could no longer hold on.

Thk, thud-thud-thud!

When Gulliver came to his senses and broke free of the ropes the Lilliputians had bound him with, what had they thought as they stared up at the giant rising above them?

I could not know for certain.

But at least I was neither shocked nor flustered.

“Well, look at you.”

It made no difference anyway.

The three hardcore ranged-DPS addicts—or rather, three Supreme Peak masters—had followed my orders perfectly, and the Mutated Water God Dragon had suffered devastating damage.

Even if it pulled out the spears embedded in its tail and gathered Water Breath now, nothing would change.

Shiiiiing, tap!

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space.

Like the other spears, White Flame had been torn free by the force of the dragon’s tail and sent spinning through the air.

Then it was sucked into my hand.

I raised White Flame’s spearhead, slick with dark-blue blood, and pointed it at the bastard.

“From now on… hack apart anything you can reach.”

My voice came out as hot as lava.

The three people who had grown accustomed to waiting for my orders sprang into action like beasts freed from their leashes.

Snap!

Jeok Cheongang, Mungyeong, Cheongpung—and me.

The first and strongest raid team in the history of the Murim shot toward the enormous body of the monster writhing in agony.

Shweeeeeek!

Four superhumans stepped out toward four different points.

And four streaks of Force carried unprecedented power.

Shwish-shwish-shwish-shwish! Shrrk!

Fwoosh, kwaaaaaaang!

East, west, south, north.

Above, below, left, right.

There was no opening through which the dragon could escape and no direction in which it could dodge.

They were everywhere.

And nowhere.

Its body, as large as a small mountain, was the largest target imaginable. Its mangled tail could overturn river and earth alike, but it could not touch the figures flashing around it like streaks of light.

The Mutated Water God Dragon.

The greatest advantage of this corrupted being, which had spent hundreds of years growing to its immense size, had now become its greatest weakness.

—Krooooooooar!

There was no shield that could not be broken.

No door that could not be opened.

In a span too brief to even call a moment, dozens of streaks of Force carved the monster’s body apart and left it in a horrifying state.

Its dangerously beautiful jet-black scales shattered into pieces.

Its flesh and bones, so tough that ordinary blades could not even scratch them, had long since been slashed and crushed beyond recognition.

Craaaack, shaaaaaah!

Dark-blue blood gushed from its wounds and soaked the earth.

The thunder and lightning that had struck without pause began to fade.

The storm winds and driving rain slowly died away.

And so did the life of one being.

Shrrk!

—Krrk…!

Pain struck the Mutated Water God Dragon once more.

Its body writhed feebly, and then a figure appeared in the pupil of its eye.

A young human with a familiar face.

Its mortal enemy.

The one it absolutely had to kill.

—Gwooooooooar!

And the presence of one man alone—Jin Taekyung—roused the monster's last fading reserves of strength.

Gooooooong—!

At the very moment a massive sphere of water, what someone called Water Breath, was about to be completed after the dragon poured out every last bit of its strength…

Then the young human vanished from before its eye.

The next moment, the Mutated Water God Dragon heard a low, steady voice.

"You've worked hard."

Thk!

Chapter 478

I hadn’t been aiming for that spot from the beginning.

No. I hadn’t even known it was there.

It was like trying to find a squirrel hidden in a dense forest.

The Mutated Water God Dragon’s body was simply too enormous for me to spot it, and I had never imagined there could be such a gap in a part of its body it had guarded so thoroughly throughout the battle.

But…

That.

There it was.

A weakness capable of severing the windpipe of this gigantic monster.

And I did not let the perfect opportunity to finish the fight slip away.

Thk!

—Krrk…!

Living creatures were truly remarkable. They constantly evolved, adapting to their surroundings and compensating for their weaknesses.

If even humans, whose average life span was only now approaching a hundred years, could do that, then surely this exalted being, which had lived for centuries, was no different.

Was it coincidence? Or fate?

Either way, it didn’t matter.

The only thing that mattered now was that a gap exactly one scale wide had been left in the monster’s neck, which was otherwise covered in its toughest scales.

And I hadn’t missed it.

“You’ve worked hard.”

Those final words of encouragement were a privilege only the victor could enjoy.

I had driven my spearhead precisely into the underside of its neck—where a human’s Adam’s apple would have been. Tightening my grip on the shaft, I shoved it deeper.

Thk—!

The dragon’s scaled jaw trembled with a short groan, as though it were trying and failing to draw breath.

Then its jet-black pupil quivered, and the sphere of water on the verge of completion inside its wide-open maw began to disperse.

Shhhhhhh!

An incomplete Water Breath was nothing more than ordinary water.

I did not avoid the deluge pouring down over my head. I let it hit me full-on.

The unusually cold water of Dongting Lake soaked me from head to toe, calming my mind.

I won.

At the same time, a thrill surged up my spine.

The end of a long, brutal battle.

Once again, I had survived and buried my spearhead in the neck of a powerful enemy. And as always, the end of a life-or-death battle came down to two words.

Vertical and horizontal.

The victor standing tall and the loser collapsing.

Even an evil beast that had lived for an unfathomable span of time was no exception to that absolute law of the jungle.

Whooooooosh. Splash!

The body that had once possessed such immense strength and resilience gave way and toppled onto the waters of Dongting Lake.

Through the spray rising high into the air, I saw its eye blink slowly and its snout tremble faintly.

No.

I heard it.

—You are just as I remember.

"…!"

The moment someone's voice echoed inside my head, the strength drained from the hand that had been about to drive the spear in again and finish the job.

As though bewitched, I stared into the Mutated Water God Dragon's enormous eye and felt my body lock in place.

What the hell…?

The jet-black gleam and murderous aura that had made it look like a monster born beneath an ill-fated star were nowhere to be found.

Like dark clouds parting after a day of driving rain, an eye as clear and deep as the blue sky gazed back at me.

—There is no need to be surprised. After five hundred years or so, one naturally acquires abilities like this.

"Sound Transmission?"

—Perhaps it would be more accurate to call it mental intent.

The Mutated Water God Dragon—or rather, the divine being also known as the Two-Horned Beast of Dongting Lake—calmly sent its thoughts into my mind.

—You do not know me, but I know you. You look exactly as you did when I saw you in a dream long ago. I dismissed it as an idle dream and forgot all about it… Yes. This, too, must be part of the natural order.

A dream? The natural order?

Damn it, what the hell is going on?

“This is… I mean…”

—Hah.

My fumbling for words must have struck it as amusing. A growling laugh rumbled from the blood-soaked corner of the Water God Dragon’s mouth.

—You cannot understand, so do not try. These are merely the ramblings of an old imugi[2264] whose cultivation proved insufficient to ascend. My only regret is that I have no time left.

The Water God Dragon’s words were true. Its body had already reached its limit and stood on the verge of death, while the light was gradually fading from its deep eyes.

Damn it.

It was too late for regrets.

I bit my lip.

Part of me mourned the Water God Dragon’s impending death. To be coldly honest, another part simply regretted the loss.

This mystical being had regained its senses moments before death. It was an important key to solving the mystery.

Dark Heaven.

There was no way a divine and wise imugi[2265] had turned into a mad evil beast that slaughtered humans for no reason.

Someone must have interfered. And if so, I could hardly leave Dark Heaven off the list when it stood at the very top of the suspects behind everything currently happening in the Murim.

“Who did this to you? And how?”

The question was brief, but it contained everything.

The Water God Dragon’s reply went far beyond anything I had expected.

—See for yourself.

“Excuse me?”

The Water God Dragon answered by blinking.

Srrk.

Blue liquid welled in its enormous eye. The liquid everyone called tears slid slowly down its scales, and the moment it touched me, I understood what the Water God Dragon had meant.

Ding.

[2264] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.

[2265] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.

SYSTEM

Water God Dragon wishes to convey a portion of its memories to you.
Memory Fragment Acquired.
The power contained within Memory Fragment is leading you into the Water God Dragon's memories.

As the System notification rang in my ears, the Water God Dragon's tear unfurled like a curtain before my eyes.

Shhhhhhh.

A cool sensation washed over me.

Then the world stopped.

It was exactly what its name suggested: a fragment of memory.

It held the five hundred years the Water God Dragon had lived, but perhaps because of the mutation, parts of it had broken away. Some memories were blurred, while others remained perfectly clear.

And everything began with its birth.

—Guruk?

Somewhere deep beneath the waters of Dongting Lake, a tiny newborn creature looked around in bewilderment.

Aquatic plants swayed as though dancing, and countless underwater creatures had gathered around it.

The subjects who sensed the birth of a divine being swam joyfully through the currents.

It was an auspicious day—the birth of a new master of Dongting Lake and the occasion of a grand enthronement ceremony.

—Guruk? Guk!

The new master of the river tilted its head with all the curiosity of a puppy, then began to swim with its tiny body.

The moment this being, gifted with dazzling wisdom and power at birth, began to move, countless creatures followed behind it, and even the river parted to make way.

Shhhhhhh!

As it cut through the waters of Dongting Lake with supple, powerful movements, its body gradually grew larger.

Silver scales sprouted across its once-small, soft pink body, and imposing whiskers grew long beneath its snout.

It was probably around then.

Those who caught sight of this divine being once every few decades—or even less often—gave it a new name out of reverence.

A name I knew well.

Water God Dragon.

Perhaps because of the two horns on its forehead, it was also called the Two-Horned Beast. But most people were reluctant to call such a beautiful and mysterious being a mere beast. Instead, they worshiped it as the divine spirit of Dongting Lake.

And the imugi[2266], having received a new name from humanity, would occasionally perform deeds that truly seemed divine.

It rescued sailors on the verge of drowning and carried them to remote stretches of dry land. It also used its innate power to calm violent currents on countless occasions.

And that wasn't all. The Water God Dragon was also the one that defeated an evil beast that had once stained the Yangtze with blood.

After a fierce battle, it slew the turtle-shaped evil beast and came to rule both Dongting Lake and the Yangtze.

Time flowed like water.

Over the course of more than five hundred years, the Water God Dragon grew beyond all comparison to what it had once been.

It was a benevolent imugi[2267] possessed of tremendous power and profound wisdom, and an excellent ruler who cared for its subjects.

Yet even the Water God Dragon had one concern.

—Huh. Fighting never ends in the Lower Realm.

The horrors it had witnessed over its long life were truly appalling.

Humans constantly fought among themselves, and whenever they did, blood and countless corpses were scattered across the waters.

Two empires fell and war followed war. The Water God Dragon grew troubled and weary.

—I have already spent an unfathomable span of time in the Lower Realm. When will I finally be able to ascend?

No matter how people worshiped it as the divine spirit of Dongting Lake and called it a dragon, the Water God Dragon was, in truth, still an imugi[2268] that had yet to become one.

For the Water God Dragon, ascension was practically a destiny determined at birth.

[2266] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.
[2267] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.
[2268] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.

But its cultivation progressed so slowly that it came to resent the heavens, and enlightenment remained stubbornly out of reach.

Then a school of fish brought news that was more than enough to stir the weary Water God Dragon's curiosity.

—You say a human has appeared? But no one has visited that place in decades.

An uninvited visitor had entered the deepest and most secluded part of Dongting Lake—a treacherous place where no human had set foot in a very long time.

Its curiosity piqued, the Water God Dragon headed for the place it had once used as its dwelling.

The moment it arrived, it realized something was terribly wrong.

—What is this…!

The Water God Dragon of the past was not the only one shocked by the sight.

Watching through the fragment of memory, I was just as stunned.

That can't be…

A clammy, sickening sensation crept slowly up my spine.

Overcome by disbelief, doubt, and the sheer shock of being blindsided, I muttered blankly.

…A Gate.

There was no doubt.

I had passed through Gates hundreds—no, thousands—of times. I was certain.

The black energy pouring in streams through the cracks between the enormous rocks was unmistakably magical power.

What the fucking hell…!

My vision swam, and every curse I knew echoed through my head.

If I had not been trapped inside the Water God Dragon's memories—if I had been able to move and shout freely—I would have smashed everything around me. I would have screamed until my throat tore open.

Fuck, a Gate. Magical power!

My head felt ready to burst from the flood of thoughts. The scream I could not release died on the tip of my tongue.

Eyes wide with shock and fury, I stared at the scene unfolding before me.

—Stop! I said stop!

The master of the lake used its entire body to hold back the countless subjects charging toward it.

The teeth of the fish exposed to demonic qi were sharper than saw blades, and their scales had turned completely jet black.

—Please, stop!

But its desperate thoughts could no longer reach the fish mutated by demonic qi, and the Water God Dragon was forced to make a terrible decision.

If those unnaturally powerful and violent fish escaped, all of Dongting Lake and the Yangtze would be stained with blood.

A sacrifice had to be made for the greater good.

—…I am sorry.

The battle in the deepest waters of Dongting Lake naturally ended in the Water God Dragon's victory.

But it was not even given time to grieve.

The wise imugi[2269], which had lived for centuries, understood what it had to do. It placed its own body over the enormous rift that ceaselessly poured out its ominous energy.

—I do not know what you are, but you will not have your way.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

It was the longest and fiercest struggle of the Water God Dragon's entire life.

For seven days and nights, the two powers remained locked in a stalemate. The waters of Dongting Lake and the Yangtze churned violently, and the people on land trembled in fear, believing the divine spirit had grown angry.

And I already knew how that struggle ended.

—Krrr…

The Water God Dragon, its dazzling intelligence lost as it fell into corruption and became an evil beast, let out a low growl.

It had protected its territory and subjects by absorbing most of the demonic qi, but it could not contain all that power.

Hissss.

Its eyes slowly turned red.

Yet its last remaining grain of reason drove the Water God Dragon to surge out of the water.

It was the will of an old imugi[2270] determined to find the culprit behind this terrible atrocity.

Shhhhhhh!

On a dark night, the blackened waters parted.

The Water God Dragon rose as though ascending to heaven, and its red pupil reflected a person sitting on a moss-covered rock and splashing their feet in the water.

"The energy here is lovely. Coming all this way was worth it."

A clear, gentle voice.

A dazzlingly white nape.

And a silver hairpin securing long black hair twisted into a knot.

[2269] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.

[2270] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being that has not yet become a dragon.

…Honglan.

The moment that name surfaced in my mind, the entire world around me shattered into pieces.

Chapter 479

The world collapsed, then rebuilt itself once more.

The ferocious red pupil, the surging river, and the beautifully crafted silver hairpin all vanished. In their place came reality beyond the memory.

Whoooooosh.

I slowly blinked. The curtain of water surrounding my body scattered, and my changed surroundings came into focus.

At the same time, time itself—frozen as though someone had pressed pause—began moving again.

Then, in the next instant, the chill in the air and a flood of System notifications crashed over me like a dam bursting all at once.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

With the Level Up notifications, a mysterious power breathed new vitality into my exhausted body and replenished my depleted internal energy.

And yet, for some reason, I could barely breathe.

Honglan. It was Honglan.

Yes. It had been her.

The Lower District Sect member who had survived the tragedy at Dongting Lake alongside Ju Wongong. A breathtaking beauty capable of swaying an entire nation.

The owner of the hairpin in my hair was the one who had corrupted a benevolent imugi[2271] and stained Dongting Lake and the Yangtze with blood—the culprit behind every incident that had occurred in Hubei Province.

Why hadn't I realized it? Where had the lies begun, and where had the truth ended?

Gate. Magical power. Honglan. Dark Heaven.

[2271] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

Countless questions and thoughts flashed through my mind in a single instant. My overloaded brain felt ready to burst.

As I trembled at the unbelievable reality, I spotted three figures shooting toward me.

Jeok Cheongang was in the lead, his face contorted with fury.

“You bastard, how dare you—!”

Thinking about it, the scene was easy to misread.

My conversation with the Water God Dragon and the time I had spent inside the Memory Fragment had both taken place within an incredibly brief instant. To everyone else, I had been standing there perfectly fine before suddenly starting to act strangely.

Jeok Cheongang’s furious bellow snapped me back to reality, and I shouted like a bolt of lightning.

“Old Master!”

“…!”

We could understand each other’s intentions with nothing more than a glance.

The moment Jeok Cheongang recognized the emotion in my shout, an exclamation mark appeared in his eyes. At the same time, the fist he had been driving forward forcefully changed direction.

Whoom, kwaaaaaang!

It missed by no more than a hair.

The Fist Force narrowly avoided the Water God Dragon and slammed into the surface of the now-calm lake.

The heat carried by the Scorching Yang Qi was so intense that every trace of moisture within a radius of several jang[2272] evaporated in an instant.

The Water God Dragon was already at death’s door.

If that attack had struck it, there would not even have been time for a final conversation.

“You bastard, why—!”

—Were you worried about your Disciple? A fine master indeed.

“Gasp!”

It was obvious that the mental intent the Water God Dragon had sent out had not reached me alone.

Jeok Cheongang sucked in a short breath and stepped back. Mungyeong and Cheongpung arrived immediately afterward, both looking as though they had seen a ghost.

“What in the world was that just now?”

“Uh, even Mimi can’t do anything like that.”

[2272] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

…Shlick.

Our reflections appeared in the Water God Dragon's deep, clear eyes. Jeok Cheongang asked in a trembling voice,

"What… What in the world are you?"

—Some call me a divine spirit. Others call me a monster. You must find the answer to that question for yourself.

Grrr.

The Water God Dragon exhaled with difficulty and continued sending its mental intent.

—Before the end, I should thank you. Had you not intervened, I would have remained a hideous evil beast until my final breath…

The mental intent that had rung clearly inside our minds gradually faded.

The light was already draining from the Water God Dragon's clear eyes.

It's dying? Just like this?

I looked at Mungyeong with the last of my hope, but the man who also bore the sobriquet Divine Physician merely shook his head, his expression grim.

"It's already too late. Even a Great Firmament Immortal couldn't stop it now."

—You speak the truth, one who walks between life and death.

One who walks between life and death.

Mungyeong's neatly shaped brows twitched at the words that had seen straight through his identity.

"You… know me?"

—Though I failed to ascend to the heavens, I cultivated for many long years. I saw every one of you here in my dreams.

What exactly had been happening in the dreams the Water God Dragon claimed to have?

It was an imugi[2273] that had lived for five hundred years. Even now, with all its strength exhausted and death close at hand, it possessed a depth and mystery beyond anything I could fathom.

As though gazing at something beyond human understanding, the Water God Dragon stared into the empty air over our shoulders and sent out its mental intent.

—Unfortunately, this is as far as I am permitted to go. Though I cannot speak of the heavenly patterns[2274]… yes, I suppose I may leave one gift behind before I depart.

A gift?

None of us had time to voice the question.

In the next instant, my eyes widened at the faint cluster of light emerging from the blood-soaked corner of the Water God Dragon's mouth.

[2273] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

[2274] *Heavenly patterns* are celestial signs read for major changes and omens.

Shhhhhhh.

It was a pearl, glowing softly.

As though lifted by an invisible hand, it slipped free of the Water God Dragon's mouth and floated into the air. Then it began to tremble.

Whoom.

A vibration traveled through the air.

At the same time, the black stain covering much of the pearl melted away. Each time part of it vanished, the pearl visibly shrank.

This is…

What I could see was only part of it.

I could feel the sheer magnitude and depth of the qi contained within the pearl, and the sight unfolding before me brought a single word to mind.

Purification.

At last, when the transformation was complete, an irrepressible gasp escaped someone's lips.

"Ah."

Shhhhhhh.

The pearl now shone with a radiance far brighter than before.

Although it had shrunk to roughly the size of an ordinary pill, the crystal of qi, cleansed of every impurity, contained power of immeasurable clarity and depth.

So pure.

It was an incredibly powerful crystal of qi.

As all of us stared at it in awe—

Slither.

The crystal of energy slowly drifted through the air and stopped in front of me. At the same time, the Water God Dragon's mental intent rang out.

—This is my Origin Essence. Humans call it an inner core.

"…!"

—Though it is insignificant compared to what it once was, it will surely become a great source of strength. Please use it where it is needed.

I had no reason to refuse.

I stared at the crystal with trembling eyes, then reached out and took it.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Water God Dragon's Origin Essence acquired!

The System notification rang in my ears.

Having given me everything it possessed, the Water God Dragon slowly blinked.

A faint smile lingered in its eyes as it gazed up at the clear sky.

—So this is where it ends…

Grrr.

Along with the fading mental intent, the final breath of the imugi[2275] that had failed to become a dragon escaped from its blood-soaked mouth.

Then everything stopped, and silence descended.

I reached out and closed the Water God Dragon's eyes, which had grown cold and stiff.

You've worked hard.

I had witnessed the Water God Dragon's life through the Memory Fragment.

It had been a mysterious being far beyond any ordinary spiritual creature, and a benevolent one that had sacrificed itself to prevent an even greater disaster.

So at least in its final moment, it deserved the right to meet death on its own terms.

Not as a sacrifice for someone else's Level Up, but as a natural death.

But there was one person—no, one bitch—who was the exception, no matter what.

…Honglan.

I pulled the silver hairpin from my hair.

It gave off a scent so faint that even my keen sense of smell could barely detect it. I stared at it in silence, then turned to the still-confused Jeok Cheongang.

"Want to go catch a snake?"

"First tell me what the hell is going on… What? A snake?"

"Yes. A flower snake."[2276]

A clear peal of laughter rang across the deck of the military vessel, drawing everyone's attention.

Though the laughter was not the only reason they were looking.

Every man with eyes had been stealing glances at her since before they boarded the vessel. She was that beautiful.

"Good heavens. Even her laughter is beautiful."

When a middle-aged man in a military uniform muttered wistfully, the colleague beside him scolded him.

"Your wife should have seen you just now."

[2275] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

[2276] In Korean slang, a "flower snake" is a woman who seduces men and exploits them.

"Don't say such unlucky things. I'd rather lock eyes with Yama."[2277]

"You're old enough to know better, and you have five children as cute as rabbits. Are you seriously acting like this?"

"What about you?"

"I don't have any children yet."

"You have a wife."

His fellow soldier solemnly declared,

"Not for much longer."

"…You've completely lost your mind. Are you serious?"

"What's wrong with me? A man ought to try his luck at least once."

"I guarantee you won't get the chance."

"Are you trying to jinx me before I've even started?"

"No. Someone much younger, better-looking, and more capable than you has already made the first move."

He was telling the truth. A military officer with striking, handsome features was already striding confidently toward the woman.

"Young Lady. I assume something pleasant has happened?"

Officer Song, who was in charge of the military vessel, flashed his white teeth in a broad grin.

He came from a wealthy family and was handsome to boot. The woman before him might be a breathtaking beauty the likes of whom he would see only once or twice in his life, but he still had confidence in himself.

She isn't some young lady from a prestigious household. She's only a singing courtesan.

The very next moment, that confidence crumbled without a trace.

"Yes. Something very pleasant."

Her voice was so pure it seemed to cleanse the soul, and her smile was like hydrangeas in full bloom.

Her beauty was seductive yet pristine, pristine yet so lofty that no one dared approach.

Officer Song began to stammer without realizing it.

"I-is, is that so?"

At his flustered appearance, the woman—Honglan—covered her mouth and laughed.

Her eyes curved like half-moons, drawing anguished groans from the officers who had been stealing glances at her.

How dare those bastards.

[2277] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld.

Officer Song glared at his subordinates, then spoke over the pounding of his heart.

"What a shame. If only I could share that pleasure with you, Young Lady…"

Honglan smiled faintly at his deliberately trailing words.

"I'm not sure. I'm hesitant to say anything careless in case I unsettle our Officer Song's heart."

Our dear Officer Song?

There was no doubt about it. This was the green light that supposedly appeared between a man and a woman who had feelings for each other.

Emboldened, Officer Song bellowed,

"On my ancestors' honor, that will absolutely never happen!"

"Oh my, how brave. Then I'll let only you in on it, Officer Song. Bring your ear a little closer…"

"Yes, yes!"

Officer Song leaned his ear toward Honglan, his heart pounding.

Then her sweet, warm breath tickled his ear.

"The truth is, I used the imugi[2278] living in Dongting Lake to kill a great many people."

"What?"

"But that imugi[2279] just died. I'm sorry to see it go, but at the same time, I'm delighted."

Officer Song slowly lifted his head and stared blankly at Honglan.

He had no idea what the woman before him was talking about, or what he had just heard.

"Young Lady, what does that—"

"It's exactly what you heard. I believe you'll understand me, Officer Song."

For some reason, Honglan's languid voice made Officer Song's expression go hazy.

This was no mere infatuation. It was an irresistible pull, a chain that seized a person's emotions and soul.

"Isn't that right, Officer Song?"

"…Of course. Naturally."

"That's wonderful."

Honglan watched with satisfaction as Officer Song nodded like a man under a spell, then turned her gaze toward the broad river.

And to the man who had become her captive, she made a request—or rather, issued her first command.

"Shall we change our destination?"

[2278] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

[2279] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

Chapter 480

“Ugh.”

The wrinkled skin around the old man’s eyes twitched. He tossed and turned with a groan, then finally opened his eyes after a long while.

Where am I…?

Instead of damp, yellow-stained wallpaper, he saw a ceiling so starkly white that it was almost oppressive.

He lay there blankly, unable to make sense of the situation, until a calm voice reached his ears.

“Are you awake?”

“U-uh…?”

It wasn’t hard to find the source of the voice.

The old man sat up with a start and saw a young man seated before a small brazier, watching him.

“Wh-who might you be?”

“There are ultimately only two kinds of people in a clinic: medical apprentices and patients. Since you still belong to the latter category, you should lie back down.”

“Ah.”

Only then did the old man realize that this unfamiliar place was a clinic. He also realized the identity of the young man, who looked barely more than a boy.

“So you’re a medical apprentice, sir. But why am I in a clinic… Ow.”

As he spoke in bewilderment, a sudden headache made him groan.

Only now did he realize that his aged body ached everywhere. He was drenched in sweat and trembling uncontrollably.

Good heavens. What on earth happened?

The young medical apprentice crossed the room and came to his aid.

“I’m going to insert a few needles now. Calm yourself and breathe slowly. All right. One. Two…”

Tap.

“Wha—?”

The old man’s eyes went round. The crown of his head prickled as though an ant had bitten him, and then his headache vanished as if it had been washed away.

Holding a slender needle, the young medical apprentice smiled faintly at the old man’s astonished stare.

“Are you all right?”

“Pardon? Yes.”

“Then lie back down. From what I’ve observed over the past two days, fortunately, there doesn’t seem to be anything seriously wrong… but you still shouldn’t be moving around yet.”

“Ah, I-I understand.”

His medical skills were nothing short of miraculous, and something about his presence inexplicably put both body and mind at ease.

Up close, he looked much younger than expected, yet he seemed more seasoned than even an elderly medical apprentice.

“I’ll help you. Relax and lie down slowly.”

“Yes, yes.”

The old man lay back down as though entranced. The young medical apprentice raised several fingers.

“I need to perform a simple check. Elder, how many fingers am I holding up?”

“It looks like three.”

“And now?”

“Two.”

“Correct. Where do you live, and what is your name and age?”

“…Do I have to tell you that too?”

“I need to make sure your mind is completely clear.”

“Hmm. Let me think.”

Unlike the earlier questions, these required some thought.

The old man had only just awakened, and his condition was still unstable. Feeling a faint headache, he slowly opened his mouth.

“I’ve lived my whole life around Wuhan and Dongting Lake. My name is Gwak Bongchul. No one kept proper track when I was growing up, so I don’t know my exact age, but I reckon I must be past seventy.”

“So you’re Elder Gwak. You’re remarkably fit for your age. What do you do?”

“I… Well, I…”

The old man frowned and hesitated until his occupation came back to him.

“I row a boat.”

“You’re a boatman.”

“Yes. When I was young, I worked as a deckhand on a merchant ship. After I bought my own boat, I mostly carried passengers around Dongting Lake and showed them the sights.”

Before long, the old man—no, the elderly boatman—was delving into old memories and talking without prompting. Each time, the young medical apprentice encouraged him with a gentle smile and a nod.

“There was an older fellow I used to work with. He put it into my head that a man with his own boat was bound to find himself a woman. So I took the plunge and bought a sleek little beauty made by Baekchu.”

“Is that so?”

“I don’t know if you’ve heard of Baekchu, sir. These days, boats like that are common at the Wuhan ferry docks, but when I was young, a man who sailed a Baekchu vessel was considered a first-rate husband prospect. That, or an Audi. You know, the one with four circles on the bow.”

“That sounds somewhat like Five Qi Returning to Origin.[2280]”

“Huh? What’s Five Qi Returning to Origin[2281]?”

“It’s something. Let’s move on.”

“Anyway, that boat I bought was sleek and beautiful. It attracted plenty of women, too. Once, a widow from the neighboring village came to me late at night and asked me to show her the Baekchu. Then, all of a sudden, she yanked her dress ties open…!”

“…Let’s skip a little farther ahead.”

The young medical apprentice listened with patience far beyond his years. As the story continued, the solid dam blocking the boatman’s memories slowly began to crumble.

Then, while the boatman cheerfully rambled on, his aching body forgotten, one particular memory suddenly resurfaced.

He froze like a stone statue.

“…!”

It was a bolt of lightning.

A nightmarish memory.

Rumble. Boom!

Graaaaaaah!

The crash of thunder and a furious roar rang vividly in his ears.

He blinked slowly, and the image of a colossal being silhouetted against the black sky flashed before his eyes.

“Gah!”

The boatman sprang upright without realizing it and stared blankly into the air.

“W-wait. Wait a moment.”

His voice trembled, and his eyes were wide open.

Perhaps because he had exerted himself so suddenly, every part of his body began aching again. But the boatman paid no attention to any of it.

[2280] Five Qi Returning to Origin is a high realm of martial cultivation; its name draws on the Daoist idea of five vital energies returning to their source.

[2281] Five Qi Returning to Origin is a high realm of martial cultivation; its name draws on the Daoist idea of five vital energies returning to their source.

The memories flooding back through the broken dam consumed his thoughts.

“Me-medical apprentice! What did you say to me earlier?”

“What are you referring to?”

“Two days! Didn’t you say two days had passed?”

Grab!

A grip far too strong for a man over seventy clamped around the medical apprentice’s slender wrist.

But the young medical apprentice did not so much as twitch an eyebrow as he calmly replied,

“That is correct.”

“Good heavens. How could this happen?”

“Calm yourself, Elder.”

“T-this is no time to be calm. We must tell the people and report this to the higher-ups at once!”

The boatman was half out of his mind.

His entire body was drenched in sweat and trembling without his realizing it, while his unfocused eyes darted anxiously in every direction.

It was as though something might devour him at any moment.

“We have to run as quickly as possible. Hurry!”

That was when the young medical apprentice reached toward the patient, who was shouting as though in the throes of a fit.

Swish.

A smooth white hand without a single callus touched the boatman’s slightly hunched back. Warmth flowed from it and filled his body.

The inexplicable phenomenon finally calmed the boatman, and he gasped for breath.

“Wh-what was that?”

“Think of it as a miscellaneous technique I’ve practiced from time to time. And, Elder.”

“Gasp.”

The boatman met the medical apprentice’s deep, clear gaze, and for reasons he could not explain, the words caught in his throat.

The young medical apprentice studied him for a moment before slowly continuing.

“The thing you’re worried about will never happen. Do you understand?”

“Pardon?”

“It’s simple. Erase everything you saw, heard, and experienced from your mind. Two days ago, you were summoned to Dongting Lake with the government troops, but you collapsed because you were unwell. You woke up today.”

“P-please wait a moment.”

“Everything I’m telling you is true. It must become true. That day, you carried no passengers, and you never saw the divine spirit of Dongting Lake.”

“…!”

The boatman shuddered as though he had been struck by lightning.

The young medical apprentice’s words were that shocking.

“D-does that mean you saw the Mountain Spirit too, sir…?”

“That may be the case, or it may not. But there is one thing you must remember… You must forget everything you remember about those events.”

The boatman swallowed hard at the young man’s gentle yet blade-cold voice.

Then the suffocating silence in the room was broken by the last bit of courage a man over seventy could muster.

“D-do you intend to kill me?”

“Me? No.”

The young medical apprentice slowly shook his head and continued.

“But someone else may think differently. For example… the City Lord of Hubei Province, who would not want ominous rumors spreading.”

“T-the City Lord!”

The City Lord of Hubei Province.

An official who governed a city by order of the Son of Heaven—a man who, at least within Hubei Province, was as good as a king.

The boatman cried out reflexively at the unexpected appearance of such a high-ranking person. Then he realized his mistake, and his vision went dark.

What a stupid fool! What if someone heard me?

Unlike him, however, the young medical apprentice’s expression remained relaxed.

It was the composure of the person who had ensured that none of their conversation could leave the room.

No—even if their words did leak out, the young medical apprentice would not bat an eye.

The precaution was solely for the sake of the boatman’s life.

Unaware of that, the boatman spoke again in a tightly hushed voice.

“I-I want to live. Why on earth would the City Lord want to kill an insignificant boatman like me?”

“When floods come, droughts strike, and plagues spread, people die in every direction, and wars break out everywhere. Then the rebels who dream of becoming kings and high officials speak with one voice. They say that the will of Heaven has left the Son of Heaven. That we should overthrow this rotten country.”

The young medical apprentice clicked his tongue softly, stood up, and tossed out one final remark.

"Even disasters beyond human power lead to such things. So what do you suppose would happen if the divine spirit of Dongting Lake, a creature as vast as a mountain, went mad and ran wild?"

"…!"

"Thousands died. The Yangtze and Dongting Lake were filled with corpses and blood, and streets that once blazed through the night fell dark. Now, with the frightened people watching Hubei Province, what do you think would happen if everyone learned what you saw and heard?"

He left the rest unsaid, but in the suffocating silence, the boatman found the answer himself.

I'd die. Without a doubt.

He had been born into a poor tenant farmer's family and lived his entire life illiterate, but he had not spent more than seventy years with his eyes and ears closed.

If anything, ferrying countless passengers had taught him how the world worked through the conversations he overheard.

If I so much as breathe a word about what I know…

It would be the end of him.

Neither the Son of Heaven seated upon the throne nor the City Lord of Hubei Province would want people to learn that the mad divine spirit of Dongting Lake had killed thousands.

No, perhaps they would eliminate everyone involved in the matter immediately.

A martial artist from a prestigious sect might be another matter, but an old boatman past seventy could be disposed of without anyone ever knowing.

"Good heavens. Oh, good heavens…"

As the boatman exhaled like a man whose soul had left his body, a lifeline was extended to him.

"Erase it all from your memory. Sell your boat, keep your mouth shut, and live out the rest of your days. Do that, and nothing will happen."

"W-will that really be enough?"

"That is all I have to say."

The young medical apprentice rose from his seat. The boatman stared dazedly at his departing back, then hurriedly called out.

"A-are you really a medical apprentice, sir?"

"Of course."

The young medical apprentice, Mungyeong, answered without hesitation and released the doorknob.

Then he pointed to the brazier still burning in the corner of the room and the kettle slowly boiling atop it.

“I boiled that decoction myself. Three times a day. After meals. Make sure you take it.”

Caring for a patient until the very end was a medical apprentice’s duty.

Chapter 481

Creak. Click.

Mungyeong closed the door, leaving the boatman alone, and thought,

That should be enough.

Perhaps because he had lived so long, the boatman was far quicker on the uptake than Mungyeong had expected.

He would have to spend the rest of his life under the authorities' watch, but that was still a hundred times better than turning up dead without anyone knowing how.

The deal with the City Lord of Hubei Province had already been struck. As long as the boatman kept his mouth shut, he could live out the remainder of his days in peace.

Besides, even if he did talk, everyone would dismiss him as a senile old madman.

And he won't have to worry about money anymore. All things considered, it's not a bad arrangement for him.

Mungyeong wondered what expression the boatman would make when he discovered the money pouch beside the brazier. He also recalled what the person who had asked him to deliver it had said.

"He came along for no good reason and nearly died. The least we can do is give him hazard pay and workers' compensation."

Workers' compensation?

It was a bizarre term Mungyeong had never heard before, but then again, Jin Taekyung had always been like that.

A brat so young he was practically yellow instead of merely green—and one who never stopped surprising him.

I can't make sense of him at all.

Mungyeong could have listed his peculiarities forever, but after everything that had happened, that impression had only grown stronger.

He recalled how Jin Taekyung had not shrunk back before that enormous, unprecedented monster. If anything, he had rampaged even more wildly.

Mungyeong's brow furrowed.

Natural courage? Perhaps. But there was something else… Yes. He looked accustomed to it. Like a battle-hardened veteran who had survived countless battles.

Had fighting Dark Heaven made Jin Taekyung accustomed to the bizarre phenomena known as supernatural powers?

Or did Jin Taekyung possess some secret no one else knew?

Mungyeong was walking along, lost in thought, when voices reached him.

"Physician Song, I heard they caught those bastards who deserve to die."

“Good heavens. ‘Bastards who deserve to die’? Hyang, you’re a medical apprentice. How can you use such harsh language…?”

In the busy courtyard of the clinic, an older, middle-aged medical apprentice was scolding a young female medical apprentice who did not even look twenty. She pouted.

“A medical apprentice is still a person, isn’t she? Besides, those men deserve to die.”

“Ahem. Watch your words. You may be right, but I’m afraid someone might hear you.”

“You’re only saying that because of that gentleman, aren’t you? What does it matter? He’s too far away to hear us anyway.”

Contrary to the young woman’s carefree assumption, Mungyeong heard and saw everything happening around him without missing a thing.

That included their conversation.

“What do you think, Physician Song?”

“About what?”

“Oh, come on. Don’t pretend you don’t know. What else could I mean but the dark-path figures of Murim who committed those heinous crimes at Dark Heaven’s instigation?”

“What could a mere medical apprentice like me possibly say? I’m simply grateful the culprits have finally been captured. All I can do is devote myself to my duties.”

“But don’t you think it’s strange? The Sea Serpent Society’s ship sinking at Red Cliffs, the tragedy at Dongting Lake, even all the deaths involving the river bandits beyond Tianling Falls… They’re saying those men were responsible for everything.”

“Strange? In what way?”

“Well, it’s just… Hmm. You know Sister Hwang, right?”

“You mean Medical Apprentice Hwang?”

“Yes. She told me something. Um…”

The young medical apprentice trailed off and glanced around. Then she rose onto her toes and whispered.

It still sounded as loud as thunder to Mungyeong.

“She said the patient she’s looking after is a pretty famous wandering martial artist, and when he heard the story, he snorted. He said that no matter how many dark-path figures there were, they’d never be a match for the Yangtze One Saber.”

“The Yangtze One Saber?”

“That’s the name—or rather, the sobriquet—of the river bandit chief who suffered a disaster this time. Apparently, his martial arts are so powerful that there isn’t a martial artist anywhere who hasn’t heard of him.”

"…And?"

"According to what the wandering martial artist said, the authorities rounded up so many dark-path figures this time to cover something up."

Mungyeong gave a silent, derisive laugh. The middle-aged medical apprentice's face stiffened.

"Hyang, have you told anyone else about this?"

"No. I'd only just heard it when Physician Song called for me, so I came straight here."

"What about Medical Apprentice Hwang? Did anyone else hear it besides you?"

"Why are you suddenly acting like this, Physician Song?"

"Answer me."

The genial-looking medical apprentice's face hardened as he questioned her. The young woman replied in a tiny voice.

"No one else was there. It was just the two of us. And I was the first person Sister Hwang told."

"Phew. That's fortunate, at least."

"Did I do something wrong?"

"No. You and Medical Apprentice Hwang were merely careless because you're both still young. But from now on, it would be best not to discuss this matter. Do you understand?"

"Ah. Yes."

"Hyang."

The middle-aged medical apprentice gently patted the cowed young woman on the head and continued in a kindly voice.

"Those dark-path mongrels who committed such heinous crimes will be executed at noon tomorrow—some by beheading, others by being torn apart by chariots. Their severed limbs will roll through the streets of Wuhan, and the ground will run red with blood."

"What?"

"This is all thanks to the City Lord, who acted on the orders of His Majesty the Emperor, and to Great Hero Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who personally exterminated the culprits. So don't be swayed by false rumors. All you need to do is praise them."

"Yes, yes."

"No, not like that. Repeat after me. May His Majesty the Emperor live ten thousand years! A thousand years to the City Lord! A thousand years to Great Hero Jin Taekyung!"

"L-long live His Imperial Majesty the Emperor…"

"Louder!"

Is he insane?

Mungyeong stared at the middle-aged medical apprentice in disbelief and clicked his tongue inwardly.

If even a medical apprentice who could be considered educated acted like this, then the reaction of ordinary people was obvious.

They'll praise the Son of Heaven[2282] without a shred of doubt. It's only been two days, so the report on this incident probably hasn't even reached the imperial palace yet.

A fabricated lie. A hidden truth.

The world never changed.

Mungyeong gave a small shake of his head and continued walking.

After leaving the clinic, which stood within the vast Hubei provincial government compound, he headed straight for a large estate among the many pavilions, one reserved for honored guests.

There, he found a master and Disciple proudly displaying the depth of their affection for each other.

"Say that again. What was that? 'Jeok Cheongang'? 'Take a shit'?"

"Old Master, please calm down…"

"I'll pin your limbs down and shit on your face."

"Whoa. Is that your thing?"

"You fucking piece of—"

"Dormammu,[2283] I've come to take a shit. Ah, sorry. It slipped out on instinct."

"I swear on the ancestors of our sect, I'll stuff shit into your mouth!"

"Waaah! Somebody save me!"

"Get over here this instant!"

Swish! Swish! Swish! Whoooosh!

"…"

As he watched the fierce chase unfold, a thought occurred to Mungyeong.

What an affectionate—and filthy—master-and-Disciple relationship.

Fortunately, Jeok Cheongang did not end up shitting in my mouth.

Of course, that didn't mean things ended peacefully or normally.

Bam!

"Ah, wait. That hit bone…"

Boom!

[2282] *Son of Heaven* is a traditional title for the Chinese Emperor.

[2283] Dormammu is a character from *Doctor Strange*. The line parodies the repeated phrase "Dormammu, I've come to bargain."

"Ugh!"

Goddamn it. Isn't using Flame Divine Palm going too far?

He had drastically reduced its power, presumably because he possessed at least a shred of human conscience. But still—how could he use Flame Divine Palm against his Disciple? No, against me, who was practically his Disciple?

My insides are getting nice and warm.

Who needed gukbap?[2284] One bowl of Flame Divine Palm, and I already felt full.

"Ugh…"

As I groaned and clutched my chest, Jeok Cheongang spoke in a sinister voice.

"Stop whining and get up."

"Is it… over?"

"It's nowhere near over. How dare you speak so casually to a master as high as the heavens…"

"Master?"

"Ahem. Not merely a master as high as the heavens, but this old man, who is even higher than the heavens. Do you think I raised you so I could be treated like this?"

"…My mother raised me, though. Why are you taking credit, Old Master?"

"You insolent brat!"

Just as Jeok Cheongang's eyes began blazing, a lifeline descended from heaven.

"That's enough."

Someone had entered without making a sound. At Mungyeong's single remark, Jeok Cheongang frowned.

"If you came in, you should have quietly watched. Why interfere?"

"It seemed excessive, so I stepped in. Is there a problem?"

Damn. He's got so much charisma. No wonder all his targets ended up dead when he was an assassin.

I gazed at Mungyeong with emotion welling in my eyes.

"Oh, what a saint…"

"Look at this brat. He's babbling nonsense again. I suppose he'll need to be beaten for quite a while before he comes to his senses."

Jeok Cheongang ominously rolled up his sleeves, but Mungyeong shook his head.

"Stop. This is excessive."

"You've been getting on my nerves for a while now. Why do you keep meddling in other people's business…?"

"No matter how I look at it, this is excessive. Shouldn't I get a turn too?"

"Ah. Fair point."

"…"

[2284] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup, a common Korean comfort food.

Goddamn it. So that's what he meant.

The moment Jeok Cheongang graciously yielded his place to the next batter, a brilliant silver streak lashed out like a whip.

Swish. Shhk!

A chill ran down my spine, and cool air slipped through the gap in my severed clothes.

I swallowed hard as my shirt split cleanly into two halves, falling open to either side.

Crazy.

It had missed by a hair's breadth.

I stood there with my heart pounding while Mungyeong gazed impassively at me.

"You didn't dodge."

"I couldn't sense any killing intent."

"You could still have dodged."

"What would've been the point? If I dodged, I'd only get hit twice instead of once. You weren't planning to kill me anyway, were you?"

"As expected, you're strange. Strange enough to put me in a bad mood."

Really? For someone who's in a bad mood, your expression is pretty ambiguous.

Jeok Cheongang, on the other hand, looked unmistakably pissed off.

"How dare you swing a sword at my Disciple?"

"Disciple?"

At Mungyeong's questioning repetition, Jeok Cheongang hastily corrected himself.

"How dare you swing a sword at that bastard who isn't even fit to be called my Disciple?"

"Is that really something you can say after beating him like a dog with martial arts?"

"Whether I beat him like a dog or drive him like an ox, I'm the only one allowed to do it! And use your fists! Not a sword!"

"…"

I knew he was trying to look out for me, but somehow, that only made me feel sad.

Mungyeong narrowed his eyes as he listened to Jeok Cheongang's utterly incoherent argument.

"I can feel my innate qi draining away just standing here. Enough. I didn't come for this pointless exchange."

Before Jeok Cheongang could say anything else, I hurriedly spoke up.

"Are you coming back from the clinic?"

"Yes. I went to check on the Dongting Fisherman and meet the boatman."

"How are they?"

"The boatman has regained consciousness. There are no unusual symptoms, and he's sharp enough to understand what he's told. The Dongting Fisherman, on the other hand… isn't doing well."

I nodded gravely.

The boatman had been knocked unconscious by a Pressure-Point Strike before he was properly exposed to Fear.

The Dongting Fisherman was the exact opposite. This was only my guess, but he must have encountered the mutated Water God Dragon at Donghu Stronghold and been severely exposed to Fear.

"He must be in pretty bad shape. Though I suppose it's only natural that he's not in his right mind…"

"His injuries are severe."

"What?"

"All four of his limbs were crushed, and his internal injuries are considerable. He's a Supreme Peak master, and the City Lord gave him an elixir, so he should recover quickly. But that imugi[2285] must have gotten him good."

"…"

"What's wrong?"

"…Nothing. It's nothing."

It seemed I had forgotten to tell him.

I had truly, genuinely forgotten.

I'd had plenty of chances to mention it over the past two days, but I had forgotten anyway.

I was pretty preoccupied, to be fair.

Of course, that was because I had been tracking one person.

Honglan.

The culprit behind this entire incident.

The woman who had corrupted the imugi[2286] that had guarded the Yangtze and Dongting Lake for more than five hundred years and caused countless deaths.

And the woman I had never managed to find.

Where the hell did she run off to?

I pulled out the silver hairpin without realizing it and stared down at it, lost in thought.

Bang!

Someone burst onto the grounds, throwing open the main gate as if he meant to tear it down.

[2285] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent often associated with dragons.

[2286] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent often associated with dragons.

Gung Gibang must have raced here using his movement technique at full speed. He struggled to catch his breath before speaking.

“Huff. Hah… I found Honglan’s trail.”

“…!”

Chapter 482

“We found a trace of Honglan.”

Gung Gibang’s announcement did not agitate only me. Immediately after the battle with the Water God Dragon ended, Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong—both of whom already knew what we had learned about Honglan’s identity—reacted as well.

“You found that goddamned bitch?”

“What happened?”

After Jeok Cheongang’s blunt question and Mungyeong’s shameless question, asked while he was still concealing his identity, I spoke grimly.

“A trace?”

The result was what mattered.

Gung Gibang had not said they had found Honglan. He had clearly said they had found *a trace of Honglan*, and the implication was obvious.

“You didn’t find her.”

Gung Gibang had finally caught his breath. He nodded.

“Not yet. But I’ve sent messenger pigeons to our disciples, Wudang, the Zhuge Clan, and the government troops, so soon—”

“No. You won’t find her.”

I answered firmly and continued.

“If she were that easy to catch, we would’ve picked up her trail long ago.”

The government troops were idiots with nothing but numbers on their side. The Beggars’ Sect, Wudang, and the Zhuge Clan were at least reliable, but the chances of them finding Honglan…

Slim, no matter how I looked at it.

Even setting aside my gut feeling that there was no way she would be caught this easily, if she had a Moving Formation hidden nearby, we would all be like dogs left staring at the roof after the chicken got away.

“What kind of trace did you find, and where? Tell me everything.”

“A military vessel was found at Red Cliffs.”

“Don’t tell me it was…”

“That’s right. The very vessel where Honglan was last seen. The authorities have already confirmed it.”

Two days ago, shortly after we left to find the Dongting Fisherman, the government troops had attempted to take Honglan to the Hubei provincial government.

She was the only survivor besides Ju Wongong, a member of the Huang tribe. On the surface, she was also one of the chief contributors to his rescue, alongside me.

From the authorities' perspective, taking her with them had been the obvious choice.

Though that was the last time anyone saw her.

After that, the military vessel Honglan had boarded vanished like a ghost.

So did the roughly one hundred government troops and sailors aboard it.

And now Gung Gibang had brought us news that the same vessel had been found.

"…And? What happened?"

In truth, I already knew the answer before I asked.

They're probably all dead.

I had already heard that the people who boarded the vessel with Honglan were ordinary men with no connection to Dark Heaven.

There was no way Honglan had tossed them a few coins for their trouble, waved goodbye, and gone peacefully on her way.

The grim expression on Gung Gibang's face only supported my guess.

Except—

"Ninety-four in total. Every one of them committed suicide by stabbing themselves in the throat."

"What?"

That, I had not expected.

I blinked silently, then somehow managed to force out my voice.

"All those people… committed suicide together?"

"Without a doubt. They stabbed themselves in the throat with the daggers they carried as standard equipment. When the bodies were examined, they were said to have died with smiles on their faces. Of course, Honglan was nowhere to be found."

"What the hell?"

I would not have been this shocked if Honglan had simply killed them herself.

But this was a kind of death far beyond anything I had imagined.

A mass suicide.

And they had been smiling?

For a moment, I could not speak. Then Mungyeong and Jeok Cheongang opened their mouths almost simultaneously.

"This is…"

"Yeah. It has to be the Soul-Seizing Technique. And an extremely powerful one."

The Soul-Seizing Technique.

As the name suggested, it was one of the monstrous martial arts and supreme techniques that bewitched and controlled an opponent's soul.

I knew what it was because it had often appeared in the wuxia[2287] novels I had read, but this was the first time I had encountered it since coming to Murim.

"Wait. That actually exists?"

Jeok Cheongang stared at me as if I had said something absurd.

"Is that something the man who took down a five-hundred-year-old imugi[2288] should be saying?"

"…Well, when you put it that way, I don't really have a response."

"For untold ages, the Demonic Cult has stood at the heart of the Thousand-Year Demonic Path. Dark Heaven is the successor to that very Demonic Cult. It would hardly be strange for people who use the Soul-Seizing Technique to be running wild."

"But you said before that the Soul-Seizing Technique was nothing special."

"That's only true against this old man. The reason that wretched witch Honglan didn't use it on you from the beginning is likely much the same."

"Because I'm a Supreme Peak master?"

"To break through the wall means that one's body and mind have reached a supreme realm. And how much more resistant would you be, with your Middle Dantian awakened?"

Jeok Cheongang paused, then suddenly frowned and added,

"No. Perhaps what that bitch wanted was for you to fight the imugi.[2289]"

"Either way, what matters is that the culprit is a master of the Soul-Seizing Technique and has vanished like a ghost."

Mungyeong quietly joined the conversation, but Gung Gibang shook his head.

"There's one more thing."

"…What?"

"The investigation found that there were ninety-six people aboard the military vessel in total. Even excluding Honglan, that leaves one person."

"Wait. Then…"

"There's one survivor. The officer who commanded the military vessel, attached to the Hubei provincial government."

"…!"

A survivor?

Everyone, myself included, stared wide-eyed at Gung Gibang. He swallowed hard before continuing.

"He's on his way here now."

A brief silence followed.

[2287] Wuxia is a genre of Chinese fiction and film about martial artists and their adventures.

[2288] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with dragons.

[2289] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with dragons.

Then Jeok Cheongang spoke, his expression stiff.

"By the way, is speaking informally to this old man a trend among young people these days?"

"…I-I wasn't speaking to you, Great Hero Jeok."

"You won't come to your senses until you've been beaten like a dog on slaughter day.[2290] Get down."

"His name is Song Ho. He is the son of a prominent merchant family in Hubei Province, and thanks to his father's efforts, he was summoned by the City Lord of Hubei Province. Two days ago, the City Lord dispatched him with orders to bring in the culprit."

The middle-aged man, whose looks must have broken plenty of women's hearts in his youth, continued anxiously.

"He was a womanizer and had been involved in several scandals, but he showed talent in both literary and martial pursuits from a young age. The City Lord kept him close not merely because of his father's influence, but because he was sharp and dependable when it came to getting things done."

I didn't know what he had been like before, but he certainly didn't seem that way now.

I half listened to the middle-aged man—the Hubei Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect—and studied the young officer sitting before us, bound with rope.

His skin was dry and rough. His eyes were unfocused, as though he had been possessed by a ghost, and clear saliva dripped from the corner of his open mouth.

Drip. Drip.

Jeok Cheongang watched the young officer drool vacantly and furrowed his brow.

"He's been completely ensnared by the Soul-Seizing Technique. He's already lost his mind."

I agreed with Jeok Cheongang completely.

There was no trace of reason left in the young man before us. Instead of a promising military officer, a doll with its soul pulled out was sitting there.

"How is his condi—how is he?"

At my hurried correction, Mungyeong slowly shook his head.

"It's hopeless. I cannot say what prolonged observation might reveal, but for now, there does not appear to be even the slightest chance of recovery."

"If there's no hope, how bad is he?"

[2290] "Slaughter day" refers to *boknal*, the Korean summer dog days, historically associated with eating dog meat.

"To lose one's soul is no different from dying. In this state, he will be unable to speak or act on his own."

His condition was far worse than I had expected.

Jin Wikyung, who had hurried over after hearing that the sole survivor had been escorted here, spoke up.

"Would another renowned physician have a different opinion?"

"No matter who examines him, they will reach the same conclusion. If their opinion differs from mine, they are probably a quack."

"Good heavens. Even if the Divine Physician examined him?"

"…Yes."

Hyung.[2291] *That's the guy.*

I swallowed the words rising in my throat. The Hubei Branch Leader of the Lower District Sect—who had briefly been treated as an agent of Dark Heaven after mistaking Honglan's identity—bowed repeatedly and withdrew.

Then, just as the room fell silent—

"Ah… uh… oh."

"…!"

A cold chill raced up my spine.

Everyone around me, myself included, stared at the young officer with our eyes wide open.

His eyes remained hazy and unfocused. In contrast, his slack mouth began to twitch, and a voice slowly seeped out.

"Uh… ah."

"…That's impossible."

Mungyeong muttered in disbelief.

He had cared for and treated countless patients. With medical skill worthy of the title Divine Physician and the martial prowess of a Supreme Peak master, Mungyeong's confident diagnoses were practically absolute laws.

Or at least they had been until a few seconds ago.

"What is this?"

Mungyeong rarely raised his voice, but now he did as he swiftly took the officer's pulse.

His expression grew as complex and subtle as it had been when he looked at the Water God Dragon.

"His condition is completely unchanged. Then why?"

And in the next moment, everyone present heard the voice that flowed from between the officer's lips.

[2291] *Hyung* is how a man addresses an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“Nothing is absolute, and nothing remains unchanged forever. You’d think you would have learned that by now. Don’t you agree?”

“…!”

It was unmistakably a man’s voice—the officer’s own.

But Gung Gibang and I both recognized the echo of someone else within it. Our eyes met, and we shouted the same name at the same time.

“Honglan!”

It felt as though a bolt of lightning had pierced the crown of my head.

If Hyuk Mujin and Cheongpung had been here, they would have reacted the same way.

I looked at the young officer—or rather, at Honglan, confronting me from some distant place through the officer’s body—with a sunken gaze and spoke.

“Where are you, you fucking bitch?”

“Oh my. Our young master has a rougher mouth than I expected. Men who swear at women aren’t very popular, you know.”

“Fuck off. I’ve never been popular anyway.”

“I didn’t expect that answer. You really are a masterpiece.”

“Cut the bullshit and tell me where you are. I’ll leave you in tatters.”

“You’re cuter than I’d heard. And funny, too.”

Her familiar, clear laughter slipped out through the officer’s lips.

The corners of his mouth remained the same, yet her voice continued to flow from it. The sight was enough to raise goose bumps.

Even then, I did not miss one important phrase.

“…Than you’d heard?”

“You already know, don’t you? We have many eyes and ears. Blood Lord did most of the talking.”

“Dark Heaven. Yeah, I figured.”

Even a 99.9 percent possibility was still only a guess without that final 0.1 percent.

Honglan had revealed her identity without the slightest hesitation. She continued brightly.

“I was surprised. You’ve become much stronger than Blood Lord said you were. Then again, if that were still all you amounted to, the Western Heaven Demon Lord would have killed you before the imugi[2292] got the chance.”

Why was this happening?

My anger showed no sign of fading, yet my mind and voice were growing calmer instead.

Unlike before, I asked in a remarkably composed voice,

[2292] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature associated with dragons.

“Who are you?”

It was a genuine question.

Even as I asked, I did not expect her to answer willingly.

But Honglan shattered my expectations with a single word.

“The Southern Heaven Demon Empress.”

“The Southern… Heaven Demon Empress?”

These fucking bastards are really screwing around in every direction—east, west, south, and north.

Chapter 483

“Southern Heaven… Demon Empress?”

Honglan—or rather, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, inhabiting the body of a young military officer—spoke in a lighthearted tone.

“It’s embarrassing to hear someone else say that sobriquet aloud.”

“Embarrassing my ass. You bastards are raising hell in every direction—east, west, south, and north. So is the eastern one the East Virgin Forever-Alone, and the northern one North Korea’s Kim?”

“The sobriquets are different, but you came surprisingly close. You’re smarter than I expected.”

“…Damn it.”

Western Heaven Demon Lord and Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Even Mimi-chan[2293] could tell that those sobriquets had been created with the four directions in mind.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord was already a monster I had barely managed to defeat after several brushes with death. And there were at least three more like him?

But an even more important question remained.

I stared at the military officer’s vacant face.

“How did you do it?”

“Oh my. What could possibly have our young Great Hero so curious?”

“You know what I’m talking about.”

A strange light suddenly flashed through the officer’s slack eyes.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress gazed at me through someone else’s eyes, then casually tossed out a question.

“You saw it, didn’t you?”

“…!”

“There’s no way you could have found it in only two days. So I suppose a spiritual creature really is a spiritual creature. Then again, a five-hundred-year-old imugi[2294] would certainly qualify as a divine being.”

Having grasped everything in an instant, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress smoothly added,

“Then you must also know that I won’t answer you.”

It was all still vivid. The traces of the Gate I had glimpsed through fragments of memory. And the sight of the Water God Dragon being tainted by the demonic qi that had flowed from it.

[2293] *-chan* is a Japanese suffix expressing affection or familiarity.

[2294] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent associated with dragons.

That was something that could not—and should not—have happened.

At least not here in Murim. It was an incomprehensible phenomenon that should never have appeared in this world.

Yet the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and Dark Heaven had dragged the impossible into reality. It was enough to make me wish it were all a lie.

“What the hell are you people after?”

“After?”

The next moment, clear laughter flowed between the officer’s lips. It carried genuine amusement, not something feigned.

After laughing aloud for a while, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress continued.

“Child. I am merely a lowly servant who moves according to orders. No one can presume to fathom that person’s will.”

That person.

Everyone present knew whom those two words referred to.

Jeok Cheongang muttered in a voice that seemed to boil like lava.

“Lord of Heaven.”

Crack.

With the sound of bones shifting, the officer’s head turned toward Jeok Cheongang like a creaking wooden puppet.

“I’ve heard that a crazed old monster lives on Mount Jiuhua. Fire King Jeok Cheongang, you are correct. It is indeed that person. The greatest and noblest of all…”

“You mean a fucking bastard who wouldn’t be worth the satisfaction of burning alive. How dare you wag that wicked tongue before this old man?”

A brief silence followed Jeok Cheongang’s words, which carried a cold flame.

Then the officer’s tightly closed lips slowly parted, and a subdued voice flowed out.

“You’d best choose your words more carefully if you wish to cling to that stubborn life of yours a little longer.”

“My life?”

Jeok Cheongang snorted and turned to me.

“You tell her. What happened to everyone who came after this old man’s life?”

“They died. Every last one of them.”

“Then how would you feel about this old man adding a bitch instead of a bastard to his kill list?”

There was no question about it. I thrust up a thumb.

“You’re a true feminist of this era.”

“Femibista? What’s that?”

“It means you’re fair. You beat the shit out of everyone equally, regardless of sex or age.”

“Is that some word young people use these days? Whatever the case, I like the meaning.”

Jeok Cheongang nodded in satisfaction, then glared at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress inhabiting the officer’s body.

“You heard that? This femibista intends to punish you and that Lord of Heaven fellow, or whatever his name is. So wash your neck and wait.”

Uh. Should I stop him now, before the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist turns into the Feminist Fist?

Still, I felt much better. The confusion in my head seemed to have cleared completely.

Yeah, fuck it. We just need to beat the shit out of all of them.

Wasn’t that the Fire Gate Clan’s motto, anyway? Smash, break, and burn anyone we decided was an enemy.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress was never going to answer my questions. In that case, no matter what Dark Heaven tried, all I had to do was keep moving forward and smash through it.

I don’t have a choice anyway.

Once I had climbed onto the back of a raging tiger, there were only two paths left.

And rather than be thrown from its back, I would end this insane struggle even if I had to smash the tiger’s skull to do it.

No. I had to.

“Phew…”

I exhaled the breath I had been holding, then leaned close to the military officer. Looking through the soul-less eyes at some distant place, I spoke.

“When we meet again… you’re going to die.”

The officer’s lips twitched.

“Yes. I, too, look forward to that day. And when it comes, no one here will survive.”

His head slowly turned. His unfocused, milky eyes swept over everyone in the room one by one.

But no one avoided that chilling gaze. Mungyeong was no exception.

“You should put an end to this futile killing. A blade always turns back on its wielder in the end.”

His voice and tone were polite, mindful of the others around him. But hidden within them was a blade only a handful of people could detect.

It was the true face of the greatest assassin of all time—the supreme martial artist known as the Slaughter Saint, who had walked a path stained with nothing but blood.

“…What an unusual child. Unusual enough to make me curious about this Divine Physician.”

But the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, borrowing someone else's body, did not seem to have grasped Mungyeong's true identity.

She might have known his public identity as the Divine Physician's Disciple, but the connection between the Slaughter Saint who had vanished forty years ago and a young medical apprentice was far too tenuous.

And before the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's suspicions about Mungyeong could deepen, Jin Wikyung spoke in a heavy voice.

"I swear on the name of the Jin Family of Taiyuan that you will never touch so much as a hair on our youngest's head."

"The Jin Family of Taiyuan. Can that paltry family and its feeble martial arts truly protect that child?"

"Even a sewer rat will fight a tiger for the sake of its young. If you're curious, come and see for yourself. I'll have no choice but to show you."

Even in the face of a bizarre phenomenon far beyond the bounds of common sense, Jin Wikyung did not lose his composure.

No sooner had he finished, calm yet resolute, than Gung Gibang scratched his matted hair.

"Great Hero Jin, it would hurt my feelings if you left our Sect out."

"I forgot the Beggars' Sect. Will you join us?"

"My Master used to say that one dog-beating stick can only beat a neighborhood cur, but a hundred can beat even a tiger to death. So what do you think would happen if a hundred thousand Beggars' Sect disciples gathered?"

The true strength of the Beggars' Sect lay in its overwhelming numbers.

Their forces were so vast that no one could object to calling them the hundred-thousand-strong Beggars' Sect.

Gung Gibang, the Successor Beggar who stood only one step from the summit of the Beggars' Sect, bared his yellow teeth in a grin.

"You were such a lovely young lady. It's a shame to see you like this. But what can we do? Don't resent me too much if I smash that pretty face of yours with my club."

"Resent you?"

The corner of the officer's mouth slowly curled upward.

Through his mouth, now twisted into a grotesque smile that threatened to split his skin, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress addressed everyone.

"There's no need to be so impatient. It won't be long now…"

Her voice faded like a dying campfire.

By then, dark red blood was already flowing from between the officer's lips. Without hesitation, I seized his wrist and felt for his pulse.

Whoosh.

Internal energy surged from my dantian and poured into his body, but the death that had already begun could not be reversed.

Things that outlived their usefulness were discarded.

Perhaps that was why the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had kept the officer alive.

A puppet whose body she could borrow for a while.

Blood gushed from his mouth, then spilled in a stream.

And it wasn't only his mouth.

Dark red blood poured from his eyes, nose, and ears—from the seven apertures of the human body.

A death that could not be stopped by several jiazi[2295] of internal energy or even a Pressure-Point Strike loomed before the officer's eyes.

"It's too late."

At that exact moment, Mungyeong's voice rang in my ears.

Along with a flood of blood, one final sentence slipped from the officer's slowly parting lips.

"Everything shall be as that person wills."

Slump. Thud.

That was the end.

The officer's head drooped as the last of his vitality drained away, and his breathing stopped.

As silence descended with one man's death, the presence approaching the estate stopped outside the door.

"Um… may I come in?"

The voice was familiar.

A young man cautiously poked his head through the slowly opening door.

"Benefactor, Great Hero Zhuge Pong is looking for you."

"Not Zhuge Pong. Zhuge Feng."

"Yes. Great Hero Zhuge Pong."

"…I should just stop talking."

I sighed and rose to my feet.

I didn't ask where Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng was, where I needed to go, or why he was looking for me.

After all, I was the one who had told them about *that place* in the first place.

"So, did you find it?"

"Yes."

Cheongpung's eyes lit up.

[2295] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

“It’s exactly the place you described, Benefactor.”

That place was the very location from the Water God Dragon’s memories.

Yeah. The damn Gate.

Honglan—or rather, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—opened her eyes.

She lifted the silk curtain of the gently swaying four-horse carriage. Beyond the lattice window, dense undergrowth stretched into the distance, while the Escort Bureau’s men sweated in the hot, humid weather of the southern regions.

“Hmm.”

With her chin resting in her hand as she gazed out the window, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress looked like a painting all by herself.

Then a furious shout thundered over the heads of the Escort Bureau men stealing entranced glances at her.

“Stop gawking and focus on the delivery! Unless you want to get yourselves killed by the Miao people[2296] we’ll meet in a few days!”

Despite the rough language, the speaker was a woman of dazzling beauty.

Beneath the bamboo hat pulled low to block the sunlight, her long, straight nose was sharp as a blade, and her lightly tanned skin was pleasing to the eye.

A female escort? You don’t see that every day.

It did not take long for the female escort, who had spent quite some time berating the rough men, to notice the Southern Heaven Demon Empress’s gaze.

She eased the reins, drew alongside the carriage, and addressed her through the window.

“Is there a problem?”

“Not at all. Thanks to all your hard work, I’m traveling quite comfortably.”

“Then why are you looking at me like…?”

“Just because.”

“Pardon?”

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled sweetly.

“You’re so young and pretty. I couldn’t help looking.”

“Ah, thank you.”

The female escort, the Young Bureau Head of a small-to-medium Escort Bureau, was flustered but did her best to hide it.

The fact that the woman complimenting her was beautiful enough to make even other women fall for her was one thing. More importantly, she was a passenger

[2296] The Miao are an ethnic group of southwestern China and neighboring regions.

who had paid a considerable sum, so the Young Bureau Head's reaction was only natural.

But at the next words, she could no longer conceal her bewilderment.

"I covet it. Enough to want to take it and put it on my own face."

"…!"

"I'm joking. Just joking."

Her bright laughter rang out. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress continued in an amused voice as the female escort froze.

"So, how much farther is it to Yunnan?"

At that moment, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress could barely contain her delight.

Delight at the screams and deaths that would soon be heard in another place.

And delight at having met a new face.

Chapter 484

It wasn't difficult to find our destination. The boatmen had already made one round trip and learned the waterways, so they guided the vessel forward with practiced ease.

Whoosh…

It was hard to believe that a storm had raged only two days ago. The river was calm, and the breeze was cool.

Sitting at the bow beneath the pouring sunlight, I spotted something familiar in the passing scenery.

That's right. It was around here.

The *Memory Fragment* contained the memories left in the Water God Dragon's mind, and I had seen and felt everything from its perspective.

Naturally, that included the way to *that place*.

"Wait. Cheongpung, are we sure this is the way?"

At my sudden question, Cheongpung tilted his head.

"It is. Why do you ask?"

"It looks a little different from what I remember. Especially that cliff over there…"

"Oh, that? There were some circumstances."

"What circumstances?"

"Well, we followed the route you told us about, but the gap was so narrow that only a hand could fit through."

"Oh."

So that was why no one had set foot there for so many years. As countless years passed and sediment accumulated, the cliff had eventually blocked the passage.

That hadn't been a problem for the Water God Dragon. It could simply swim underneath instead of passing through the cliff.

Humans, however, were a different story.

"So?"

"We cut through it."

"…You cut through it?"

"Yes. The Wudang grandpa and I snipped it apart with our swords."

What the hell? He's talking about cutting through a cliff like it's a piece of paper.

But with Origami Man—no, Perfected Being Hyeongong, the Supreme Peak master Wudang was so proud of—and Cheongpung, it wasn't impossible.

Even I could have managed it without much trouble.

"Anyway, we carved straight through. It wasn't that hard. I heard the others who arrived with the second group cleaned up the rest."

"…Uh. Right."

Sometimes I forgot that I was surrounded by monsters.

And that I was one of them.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been listening to our conversation, poked Mungyeong in the ribs.

"Has the world gone mad? I don't remember things being like this when we were young. Those two are just monsters, right?"

"Don't lump me in with you. It's insulting."

"So how old were you when you became a Supreme Peak master?"

"…"

"They're the monsters."

"Yes. That must be it. Hah. Perhaps the heavenly patterns have grown clouded. Murim has changed. It certainly has."

As Jeok Cheongang lamented, the vessel continued between cliff walls cut so perfectly straight that the sight sent a chill down my spine.

Then a new landscape—and new people—gradually came into view.

Whoosh! Splash!

Peak masters swept down using the exquisite movement technique known as Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water. They stepped across the river's surface and blocked the vessel with imposing auras.

"Stop! Everyone aboard must state their names and sobriquets. Once the identity verification process is complete—"

Jeok Cheongang, already on edge after his recent aquatic lifestyle, stuck his head out with a fiendish expression.

"This old man is the Fire King."

"Gasp!"

"Stop us and you die."

"Y-yes, sir!"

"O-open the way! No one stop them!"

Whoosh!

Gung Gibang watched the figures vanish at twice the speed with which they had appeared and muttered, "Was Wudang's movement technique always this impressive? The Beggars' Sect will have to stay on its toes."

No. They had probably realized how completely fucked they were and fled for their lives.

Either way, everything proceeded smoothly after that. The vicious Fire Pokémon Jeok Cheongang needed no explanation, and my face was famous enough that anyone who failed to recognize me might as well have been working for Dark Heaven. Besides, Cheongpung and Gung Gibang were with me.

“Oh, did someone just recognize me?”

“Of course. You’re the only beggar who travels with me.”

“…”

“Wow! Someone recognized me just now, too!”

“Of course. You’re the only person who travels around with a horned water snake.”

“Okaaay…”

I ignored the dejected Gung Gibang and Cheongpung and focused on the scene ahead.

Archers had somehow climbed to the tops of the towering cliffs and stood ready to fire. I could also sense masters concealed all around us.

Wudang, the Zhuge Clan, and it looks like the Beggars’ Sect is here too.

The security was formidable.

But considering the weight and importance of the situation, that was only natural.

“Has the City Lord of Hubei Province decided to bury this matter completely?”

Jin Wikyung nodded gravely.

“For now. The common people would hardly welcome the news that a five-hundred-year-old imugi had gone mad and run amok.”

“That’s true.”

Public support was a double-edged sword.

Under normal circumstances, the simple folk would revere the Son of Heaven, but the moment a flood or earthquake struck, they would pull a Hyuk Mujin-level about-face and declare it an omen of the nation’s ruin.

And if a plague came along as part of a buy-two-get-one-free deal, the people of this era would grab the pickaxes they used to till their fields and charge out to overturn the country.

How much worse would it be if an imugi, worshiped by countless people as a divine creature, suddenly went mad and killed several thousand people?

The City Lord of Hubei Province would want to hide that truth as much as possible.

“He does agree, at least in part, that Dark Heaven is an extremely dangerous organization.”

“…He agrees *in part*? Even after all this?”

I took back what I had just said.

Concealing the Water God Dragon’s existence was one thing, but how many people had died because of this incident? And he only agreed *in part*?

He clearly still hadn’t come to his senses.

"It is a delusion born of arrogance. He believes Murim is merely Murim and that it poses no threat to their ability to govern the country. I tried my best to persuade him, but it was of little use."

Jeok Cheongang abruptly cut in with a disgruntled voice.

"Those idiot government officials haven't changed at all. They were exactly the same during the Great Faction War. When the Demonic Cult pushed down through Sichuan, they sat on their hands. Only after the civilian casualties mounted did they scramble to gather troops."

"What happened then?"

"What do you think happened? By then, the Demonic Cult had already been defeated and withdrawn, and some bastard calling himself a Great General came strutting over to take credit. He said it was all thanks to His Imperial Majesty's grace and whatnot. Since the Emperor was the master of the country, it didn't really matter who won, but congratulations on your victory. That sort of bullshit."

"You showed remarkable restraint. For you, Old Master, that was practically the patience of a Buddha."

Jeok Cheongang looked at me as if I were talking nonsense.

"Why would this old man have put up with that? I tried to beat him to death. If Hong Dao hadn't stopped me, it wouldn't have been the Great Faction War. It would have been the Great Government War, or something like that."

"…Ah. Right."

"In any case, don't expect much from the government officials. We should be satisfied that they at least turned the dark-path figures who had been sitting quietly into Dark Heaven's lackeys."

Jin Wikyung answered with a bitter smile.

"Yes. Fortunately, the people's anger and wariness toward Dark Heaven have been soaring ever since."

"They had nothing to do with this incident, but what can we do? They aren't exactly innocent, either. They're dark-path figures, so using this opportunity to uproot them wouldn't be a bad idea."

After negotiating with Murim, the government had crushed Hubei Province's dark-path figures as scapegoats to appease the people's anger. Both sides had gotten what they wanted, so it was a kind of give-and-take.

Of course, our reputations had skyrocketed once again in the process.

Whether the government would actually step in even if Dark Heaven ran wilder than it already had was another question.

As I thought about that, the vessel that had been charging forward finally came to a stop.

We docked at a temporary pier built against the cliff, and gazes poured toward us.

"That's Great Hero Jeok Cheongang."

“The Successor Beggar is beside him, too. I was wondering where the Huashan Divine Dragon had gone.”

“Wait. Isn’t that young man the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon?”

“Did you hear? There’s talk among the leaders that the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon was the one who took down the imugi…”

They thought they were whispering, but I could hear every word.

You idiots.

Annoyed by the muttering, I deliberately scowled. The area fell silent in an instant.

Then a shout broke the silence.

“Oh, you’re here!”

The middle-aged man running toward us was drenched from head to toe in mud and river water. Unfamiliar aquatic plants were tangled in his disheveled hair.

I muttered inwardly as I watched him approach.

That man is the Family Head of the Zhuge Clan?

It was something I was only now fully appreciating, but Crouching Dragon Guest Zhuge Feng was unquestionably an eccentric even by Murim standards.

“Family Head, I normally wouldn’t say anything, but there are outsiders present. Please show some decorum…”

“Ah, please move aside, Uncle.”

“Family Heaaad!”

He had clearly stuffed his dignity into a mailbox and left it there.

Zhuge Feng ruthlessly brushed aside the family elder trying to stop him, hurried over, and spoke with his face flushed.

“We found it. We really found it!”

“Yes, I know. Cheongpung told me—”

“At first, I wondered what kind of bullshit you were talking about, but it was sitting right there in the place you described!”

“…”

Wasn’t that a little too honest?

I had explained everything so earnestly, and he had dismissed it as bullshit?

Seeing my expression, Zhuge Feng continued with an appropriately solemn look.

“Our ancestor, Zhuge Wuhou, once said that one should tap even a stone bridge before crossing it. Don’t take it too personally.”

Was trotting out their ancestor whenever it suited them a Zhuge Clan motto, or was it hereditary?

I stared suspiciously at Zhuge Feng.

“…Did Zhuge Wuhou really say that? As far as I know, that’s a proverb from another country.”

“He must have said it at least once in his life. Is that important right now?”

Unbelievable.

Whether it was the Chinese over there or the Chinese over here, they were astonishingly good at copying other people’s work.

Before I could respond, Zhuge Feng spun around and started walking ahead of us.

“Follow me.”

Jeok Cheongang, who had been trembling with delight at finally being able to set foot on even a temporary pier, narrowed his eyes.

“‘Follow me’? Was that directed at this old man?”

“…I wasn’t speaking to you, Senior.”

“Then watch your mouth from now on. Straighten out that folded tongue before this old man splits you in half.”

“Yes, sir.”

“And why are you walking so slowly? This old man’s grandmother would be faster than you.”

“Hyah!”

What was with the sudden battle cry?

As alert and disciplined as the model trainee in position one,[2297] Zhuge Feng activated his movement technique and raced ahead. Not long afterward, I encountered a bizarre sight that hadn’t appeared even in the *Memory Fragment*.

“What is that…?”

“I invented that device when I was nine. Bringing it here over the last two days was quite an ordeal. What do you think?”

I nodded as I stared at the enormous stone wall standing in the river like a barrier.

“Wow. That’s incredible.”

“It’s impossible to investigate underwater for long, so we used stone cut from the cliff to seal off all four sides, then drained the water from inside. If ordinary laborers had done this, it would have taken several months at the very least.”

The mechanism Zhuge Feng had invented had played a major role, but without martial artists, no one would have even considered building something like this in two days.

“Would everyone clear out for a moment?”

The moment we descended beneath the stone wall, Zhuge Feng uttered those words, and the people who appeared to be formation experts from the Zhuge Clan withdrew like the receding tide.

Only then could I see it.

[2297] In Korean military training, recruits can be addressed by assigned numbers. The comparison evokes a trainee responding promptly to an instructor’s orders.

A towering cliff that must have stood in the same place for countless years—and an enormous fissure running directly across its center.

Swish.

The instant I instinctively reached out and touched the fissure—

An utterly ominous System notification pierced my ears.

Chapter 485

Thump. Thump.

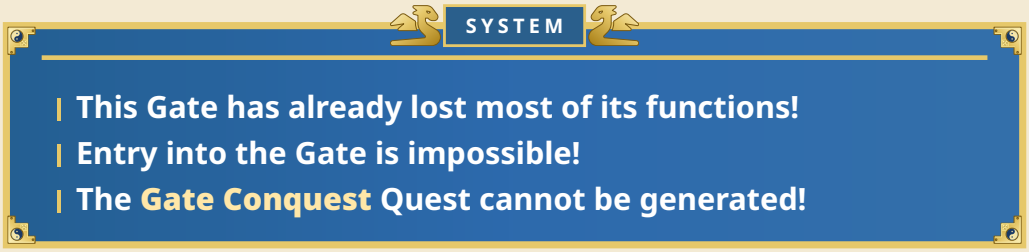
My heartbeat thundered inside me.

One step, then another. The closer I drew to *it*, the harder my heart pounded.

My mouth felt gritty, as though I had chewed a handful of sand. My eyes had gone wide without me realizing it, and they felt dry and stiff.

Then, the moment my hand finally touched the fissure in the cliff, I learned the true source of that ominous feeling.

Beep.



The notification drilling into my ears, the holographic window filling my vision, the gazes of everyone watching me…

Faced with all of it, I slowly uttered a single word.

"…Fuck."

Crunch.

Without realizing it, I had clenched my hand hard enough for my fingers to dig into the cliff.

The faintest trace of demonic qi seeped from the fissure—or rather, the Gate—and made my vision swim.

I'd hoped until the very end that it wasn't this.

That damn Gate. It really was a Gate.

How? Why?

Those unanswerable questions stayed with me for a long time afterward.

My thoughts were a mess. I had suspected as much ever since seeing it through the *Memory Fragment*, but now that I was face-to-face with a reality so difficult to believe, I found myself at a loss for words.

A Gate in the Murim.

This was an enormous rift—a sign that the laws governing this world were collapsing, and the first step toward disaster.

Dark Heaven.

Their true nature was far deeper and darker than I had ever imagined.

Standing apart from the others, I gazed out over the blackened waters of Dongting Lake. Then I picked up a loose stone and tossed it into the water.

Splash.

The bloodshed at Shaolin led to Sichuan, and eventually reached this place.

The past several months had been one continuous sea of corpses and blood.

While the Star-Array Grand Banquet was taking place in Henan, Shaolin—the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper[2298] of the orthodox Murim—had been attacked, and the flames of Dark Heaven had spread to Sichuan.

More importantly, inexplicable phenomena had occurred along the way.

The Blood Lord, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, and the Moving Formation.

I could still vividly recall the sight of the Blood Lord recovering even after being struck by Jeok Cheongang's Dance of the Fire God and Demon—a technique that staked his life itself.

No. It wasn't even accurate to call that recovery.

That was right. What the Blood Lord had shown was closer to regeneration than recovery.

New flesh had sprouted as if time itself were reversing. Bones had slid back into place. Everything charred pitch-black like ash had regenerated in an instant.

As I watched that unbelievable sight, one very familiar creature had come to mind.

A Troll. Yeah, he was just like a Troll.

Or maybe a potion…

Damn it. A Troll and a potion? It was my own idea, but it sounded insane.

What was even crazier was that it might actually have been true.

I picked up another stone and sent it flying even farther.

Splash.

And that wasn't the only strange phenomenon the Blood Lord had displayed. When the Sword Saint's arrival put him on the defensive, hadn't he cried out for the Lord of Heaven before vanishing without a trace?

At the time, everyone had concluded that it was one of the monstrous martial arts and supreme techniques born of demonic, heterodox arts. But now that I had confirmed the existence of the Gate, things looked different.

Teleport.

It might have differed slightly from the Teleport I had experienced through Magic Johnson, but if that wasn't Teleport, I'd use Hyuk Mujin's palm as a griddle.

[2298] Mount Tai and the Northern Dipper are traditional symbols of eminence; together, they describe Shaolin as a leading authority in the Murim.

Come to think of it, more than one thing hadn't added up about the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

During the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, the Western Heaven Demon Lord had sacrificed one arm to defeat the Poison King.

But when I confronted him in the underground prison beneath the Sichuan Tang Clan, he already had a new one.

No matter how many angles I considered or how many possibilities I went through, only two explanations could account for that.

Either the Western Heaven Demon Lord was a living model kit, or some unknown power had been at work.

Naturally, the former was impossible.

Though personally, I would have preferred it.

The Moving Formation was the same.

The Moving Formation. A wondrous formation capable of transporting hundreds of Dark Heaven's black-robed men at once.

Dark Heaven was called the successor to the Demonic Cult. If the Demonic Cult had possessed anything like that, they would have put it to use more than fifty years ago.

Then the Great Faction War would have ended in victory for the Demonic Cult, and instead of becoming the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, I would have become the Third Young Master of the Black Dragon Gang—or some other dark-path sect.

Why hadn't I realized it?

Even I, the sole outsider in this world of Murim, had failed to predict the truth.

The faint suspicion that had occasionally crossed my mind had been buried beneath talk of monstrous martial arts and supreme techniques from the Thousand-Year Demonic Path, then erased by the power the Western Heaven Demon Lord had called supernatural powers.

But things were different now.

I had confirmed the existence of the Gate. I had realized that the common sense and laws of the Murim, which had gradually become familiar to me, were collapsing.

And I had realized that the strange abilities of Dark Heaven—which martial artists called monstrous martial arts and supernatural powers—could be explained with a single word.

Magic.

At the single word filling my mind, my vision brightened, and my forehead, which had been burning hot, slowly cooled.

At the same time, the title of another being who had yet to reveal himself slipped from between my lips.

"…Lord of Heaven."

The one who reigned at the summit of Dark Heaven.

A being so overwhelming that people like the Blood Lord, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress called themselves his lowly servants.

What the hell are you?

Just thinking about the Lord of Heaven made all the blood in my body run cold.

If—just if—that bastard called the Lord of Heaven was the very being that had surfaced in my mind…

Splash!

"…!"

Water sprayed high into the air, sending ripples across the surface.

I snapped out of my thoughts as if I'd been doused in cold water. When I turned, a familiar face came into view. I hadn't even noticed him approach.

"What are you spacing out for?"

His voice was gruff, but the eyes peering out from between the deep wrinkles on his face were filled with concern.

I let out a quiet laugh at Jeok Cheongang's expression and opened my mouth.

"You startled me. What brings you here?"

He dropped heavily into the seat beside me.

"You'd been gone for so long that I came to see what you were doing."

"If you were coming, you could've come quietly. Why throw a rock out of nowhere?"

"Watching you fiddle with pebbles like a seven-year-old was getting on this old man's nerves. Do you have a problem with that?"

"What if I do?"

Whoosh!

Before the words had even left my mouth, I ducked. A vicious rush of air brushed my hair and tore through the space where my head had been.

Jeok Cheongang smacked his lips after his attack on the back of my head failed.

"You've got remarkably sharp instincts."

"Do you think this is the first time? I can dodge you with my eyes closed now."

"Close them."

"…I'd rather not."

"You insolent brat. Then why were you so distracted earlier? Spacing out like that in the Murim is a good way to get yourself killed."

"So you were planning to kill me?"

"Of course. If that's what you want, this old man can certainly oblige."

“Then you’ll have to find another Disciple. Oh, wait. Since I’m not actually your Disciple, I guess it doesn’t matter.”

“Ahem. Ahem-ahem!”

Jeok Cheongang forced out several fake coughs before abruptly asking,

“So what has an idiot with nothing but shit in his head so troubled?”

“I was wondering where to take a shit.”

Smack!

Damn it. I couldn’t dodge that one.

Jeok Cheongang had even used a grappling technique to make sure he landed the blow on the back of my head. He glared at me.

“Do you want to shit blood?”

“Why? You said my head was full of shit, and I said I was thinking about shit. What’s the problem?”

“Answer me properly before I switch your mouth and ass around.”

“Ah. Yes, sir.”

Rubbing the back of my throbbing head, I thought for a moment before speaking.

“The truth is, I’m not from this world. And I think an evil power from the world I originally came from is deeply connected to Dark Heaven. You know that imugi[2299] that went berserk this time? That was all their doing. The rift in the cliff is a Gate. If it ever fully breaks open, monsters will come pouring out.”

“…”

“When that happens, it’s all over. Completely over. And it’s probably not true, but there’s a bastard called Demon King Asmodeus. If he’s still alive and has his sights set on the Murim, then we’re all completely fucked—”

“I understand.”

I swallowed the rest of my words at Jeok Cheongang’s response.

It was a ridiculous story that no one would believe anyway. I had been spilling everything without restraint, but his reaction left me speechless.

“Excuse me?”

“I said I understand.”

“…”

“I understood every word. There’s no need to say any more.”

What was with that reaction?

I was beyond bewildered. At the same time, an indescribable emotion surged up from deep within my chest.

He believes me? He believes this ridiculous story? No… he believes me?

As Jeok Cheongang silently gazed at me, my chest swelled and my throat tightened.

[2299] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often described as a being that has not yet become a dragon.

A little over a year. Short by some measures, long by others.

We had shared more hardships and joys than anyone else, and the emotion in the old man's eyes was something that could only be called absolute trust.

…He trusted me that much.

Sometimes an inexplicable emotion would seize me and leave me unable to speak—unable even to figure out what I should say.

But at that moment, I realized it was time to say the word I had been turning over in my heart for so long.

"Old Master. No…"

After a long hesitation, I finally forced the words out.

As I opened my mouth, my heart trembling, Jeok Cheongang smiled kindly and nodded.

"I understood you perfectly. You sure take a long time to say that you want to die."

"M—yes?"

"What do you mean, 'yes,' you damn bastard."

Whap-whap-whap!

What the fuck?

My brain ground to a halt. I stared blankly, mouth hanging open and both hands clutching the back of my head, as his furious voice rang out.

"Do you take this old man for an idiot? What? You're not from this world? 'I Was a Mere Civilian in Another World, but Now I'm a Supreme Peak Master in the Murim.' Is that it?"

"That title's surprisingly trendy and pretty good—no, that's not the point. Just hear me out."

"I already did. Those were your last words."

"Whoa, whoa. Hold on!"

"'Hold on'? After all the times I've beaten you, you still haven't come to your senses, and now you're talking to me like an equal again, you insolent little…!"

Whap-whap-whap!

Dozens of palm shadows filled my vision and battered every inch of my body.

As searing heat burrowed into me, I thought,

Master, my ass. Fuck.

I was an idiot for getting moved, even for a moment.

"If you ever spout that kind of bullshit again, I'll tear you in half and kill you. Understood?"

At Jeok Cheongang's murderous warning, Jin Taekyung—who had been beaten mercilessly for fifteen minutes—groaned.

"Ugh, hold on. I think I'm actually going to die."

"Quiet. You're slower than this old man's grandmother!"

"…Old Master, since we're on the subject, you don't sneak out a smartphone and use it whenever you go take a leak, do you?"

Smack!

After delivering one final blow to Jin Taekyung, who had once again spouted something incomprehensible, Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue and walked away.

The murderous aura radiating from his entire body made everyone swallow hard and clear a path.

Step. Step.

He walked toward somewhere.

Now alone, Jeok Cheongang wore a complicated expression that was impossible to decipher.

…That brat. Spouting such incomprehensible nonsense.

Still, who knew?

Jeok Cheongang had never believed in rumors or superstitions—not even a little—in his entire life. But if Jin Taekyung was the one saying it, things were different.

That brat was more special to him than anyone else.

Come to think of it, he seemed about to say something beginning with "Ma…"

Could it be?

No. Of course not.

Jeok Cheongang sighed and looked up at the moon hanging over the cliff.

Beneath the brilliant moonlight, he saw someone in much the same position as himself standing nearby, gazing out over the water.

"Can we talk for a moment?"

At Jeok Cheongang's words, Mungyeong answered,

"No. Get lost."

Chapter 486

“Can we talk for a moment?”

“No. Get lost.”

“I see.”

Jeok Cheongang approached without the slightest hesitation. Mungyeong’s brow twitched.

“I said no.”

“I heard you. So?”

“You really are impossible to reason with. Did all those years go straight up your ass?”

“Young punk, is that any way to speak to an elder? This old man has at least six or seven years on you.”

“Just how old are you to say some—”

“Thigh meat, you wet-behind-the-ears brat.”[2300]

“What a goddamn—Forget it. I shouldn’t bother talking to you.”

Mungyeong, who had felt his temper flare for a moment, shook his head over and over.

He looked like a boy—so young as to seem almost childish—but he, too, had lived for more than a century.

Yet whenever he spoke with Jeok Cheongang, he felt like a child losing his composure.

He’s mastered the art of pissing people off. Master and Disciple really are two peas in a pod.

Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung could probably talk someone to death with nothing but their three-inch tongues.

Compared to them, the old Disciple tending to patients in Sichuan right now was practically the Buddha reincarnated.

I miss him. I wonder if he’s doing well.

While Mungyeong thought of his kind Disciple, Jeok Cheongang sauntered over with his splay-footed gait and sat on a rock.

“What were you looking at?”

“I have no reason to tell you.”

“Not a bad choice. Then let’s sit here until dawn. Just the two of us old men, enjoying some quality time together.”

“You understand one thing and miss the other. I can simply leave.”

[2300] The Korean word *sal* can mean both “years of age” and “flesh,” allowing Jeok Cheongang to twist Mungyeong’s question about his age into “thigh meat.”

“You understand two things and miss the third. Do you think this old man will only do this today?”

“…!”

“Today, tomorrow, the day after tomorrow, and the day after that. Old age has already robbed me of sleep and left me with time to kill. This might not be so bad.”

Mungyeong, who had been about to turn away, stopped dead. His eyelids trembling, he stared at Jeok Cheongang and muttered with a sigh.

“You vicious old bastard.”

“Hm. Looks like you’re finally ready to talk.”

“…Tell me why you came.”

“This might take a while.”

“Make it as short as possible.”

“‘As short as possible,‘ huh?”

Jeok Cheongang gazed at the river, its waters dyed pitch-black, and tossed out a single sentence.

“Look after that brat from now on.”

“What?”

Mungyeong frowned for a moment before speaking.

“By ‘that brat,‘ you mean Jin Taekyung?”

“Yes. Who else would I mean besides that brat Jin Taekyung?”

“Why are you asking me?”

“Who knows? I’m not sure myself.”

Jeok Cheongang suddenly raised his head toward the sky.

A full moon hung brilliantly overhead. Light poured from that unreachable place, unusually bright.

“I suddenly found myself wondering how long I’d be able to stay with that brat.”

A hundred years was a very long time.

Mountains and rivers had changed. Dynasties had risen and fallen. And… a young boy had become a white-haired old man.

Mungyeong gazed at Jeok Cheongang and murmured quietly.

“You’ve grown old.”

“Yes. I have.”

It was not only the body that grew old and worn with the passage of time. Unseen feelings and the heart itself were slowly weathered away.

A person realized they had grown old when death suddenly came to mind, or when they wondered how much longer they could remain beside someone.

Just as Jeok Cheongang was doing now.

And Mungyeong was the one person who understood Jeok Cheongang's feelings better than anyone.

"Has the Heart Demon come calling?"

"The Heart Demon? That came a long time ago."

Jeok Cheongang let out a self-deprecating laugh.

Ever since the former Disciple he had raised like a son became the Killing Ghost and left him, a dark cloud had hung over his heart.

The grief and guilt he had felt then had shackled Jeok Cheongang's body and mind for decades.

Until a light called Jin Taekyung suddenly appeared and shone down upon him.

"It's a painful memory now. I remember it, but it no longer hurts."

"Then why?"

"Because I've grown anxious."

The Heart Demon had no fixed form. It was any obstacle that disturbed the heart and hindered enlightenment.

The Heart Demon gripping Jeok Cheongang now was anxiety.

"I wish I'd met that boy twenty years earlier. No, even ten years earlier would have been good… But I met him too late."

Jeok Cheongang raised a hand to cover the moon. He hated how its bright light—unaged, unlike him—shone upon his wrinkled face.

"I'm not what I used to be. Neither my body nor my heart. The only reason I've endured this long is because that boy was there."

Jin Taekyung was not the only one who had grown during the year they spent on Mount Jiuhua.

Through teaching Taekyung, Jeok Cheongang had also gained a small measure of enlightenment, and thanks to that, he had managed to halt the rapid advance of his infirmities of old age.

But—

"You already knew, didn't you? My innate qi was damaged."

Innate qi, also called true-origin qi, was the source of everything that made up the human body. It was life force itself.

Remembering what had happened in Henan, Jeok Cheongang smiled bitterly.

"I don't regret it. I would have done anything to save that boy."

He meant every word. Even if he could go back ten times or a hundred, he would make the same choice. The situation had been that desperate.

Desperate enough for him to draw upon the innate qi that was practically his life force to make up for his insufficient internal energy.

The Dance of the Fire God and Demon, which had once dragged the Blood Lord to the brink of death, carried the resolve of an old Master who had burned his own life force as fuel.

“I had fully prepared myself for it. Even if I survived, I knew I wouldn’t be the same as before.”

Mungyeong watched him in silence before replying in a low voice.

“You wouldn’t have been, if not for the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng that boy brought back.”

“Yes. It was all a stroke of heaven-sent fortune. Even the fact that he found you.”

But both men knew the truth.

Not even the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, an elixir seldom seen in any age, combined with the treatment of the Divine Physician, whose medical skill was said to reach the heavens, could restore Jeok Cheongang’s innate qi.

All of it was merely a stopgap.

Even if one blocked a collapsed dam with a massive boulder, the water trapped behind the dam would continue to seep through a small gap—slowly, little by little, without pause.

“Is that why you came to me? To ask me to look after him?”

“Who knows? What do you think?”

Mungyeong clicked his tongue softly.

“You’ve grown more fretful with age. It wouldn’t be too late to worry about that a few years from now.”

Every person possessed a different amount of qi and a different vessel to contain it.

If an ordinary commoner or Third Rate martial artist was a small stream, Jeok Cheongang was an endless sea.

He would slowly lose strength as his innate qi continued to drain away, but Mungyeong already understood the condition of Jeok Cheongang’s body. As far as he could tell, these concerns were premature.

“This is my body. I know it well. At least I won’t die today.”

“Then stop thinking foolish thoughts and go back. You’d be better off spending this time grabbing that brat and teaching him one more move.”

“But no one knows what might happen tomorrow.”

“What?”

“Do you think I came because I’m afraid my innate qi will slowly disappear until I suddenly drop dead one day?”

Jeok Cheongang stared at Mungyeong’s furrowed brow and continued slowly.

“I can feel it. I’m growing weaker. I’ve already survived several brushes with death unlike anything I faced even during the Great Faction War. Whether an old man

like me can endure all the battles still to come… only some damned bastard watching from the heavens knows.”

“…!”

“Hong Dao once told me that the heavenly patterns were becoming distorted, and a calamity greater than the Great Faction War was approaching.”

Dharma King Hong Dao’s prediction had become reality.

Only a year later, Shaolin—the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper[2301] of the Murim—had been covered in blood and corpses, and the wise high monk who loved alcohol and meat had met his death.

By then, the dark cloud called Dark Heaven had spread over Henan, Sichuan, and Hubei.

And Jeok Cheongang knew that before long, it would cover the entire world.

“Listen, Slaughter Saint.”

Deep regret filled Jeok Cheongang’s eyes as he looked at Mungyeong.

“Things we cannot understand are happening. Everything we knew is collapsing.”

People often compared the Murim to the Yangtze.

The waves behind on the Yangtze push the waves ahead. That was why the saying existed.

But the strange phenomena and events Dark Heaven was causing throughout the world were nothing like the Yangtze. They were an act of defying heaven itself, overturning heaven and earth.

Everything Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong had known, every law they had understood across more than a century of life, was shattering and collapsing.

If what Jin Taekyung said is true, then even more so. No. No, that can’t be. It mustn’t be.

Jeok Cheongang forcibly brushed the thought from his mind as it flashed through it.

It was nothing more than another ridiculous piece of nonsense tossed out like a joke, just as Jin Taekyung always did.

More precisely, that was what Jeok Cheongang wanted to believe.

His body and heart had already grown old and worn. He was not yet ready to accept such a shocking story.

“Anyway, I’m only asking to put my mind at ease. Anything can happen in this goddamn Murim. It would hardly be surprising if one old man growing weaker by the day were to die.”

Mungyeong stared at Jeok Cheongang with a strange look in his eyes.

[2301] “Mount Tai and Northern Dipper” is an honorific for a preeminent authority, likening that standing to a prominent mountain and the guiding stars.

The giant known as the Fire King seemed unusually small today, and his calm voice as he spoke of a death that could come at any moment lingered in Mungyeong's ears.

Asking. He's asking me.

It was hard to believe that word had come from the mouth of the Fire King himself.

Mungyeong silently watched Jeok Cheongang rise to his feet.

Damn. I've grown old too.

Though his body had grown young, his heart was old.

That must have been why one corner of his heart, untouched by even a drop of rain for so many years, was slowly growing damp.

"…Hah."

Just as Mungyeong let out a quiet sigh, Jeok Cheongang hauled his heavy backside off the rock and turned away with a wave.

"I'll be going. Enjoy the moon."

"What?"

What was he talking about?

Mungyeong's mind briefly stopped working. He barely managed to speak.

"You're leaving?"

"Of course. Shouldn't you be grateful that this nuisance is leaving?"

"I haven't answered you yet."

"What do you mean? I believe I've already heard your answer."

"Wait. What are you—"

"I heard your answer loud and clear, young friend."

"No, what kind of crazy old bastard—"

The composure that rarely broke came crashing down all at once.

Mungyeong stared at Jeok Cheongang's retreating back with an incredulous expression and shouted,

"What do you expect me to do?"

"Teach him a few things. The mindset he'll need, for example. And if any of your secret martial arts might be useful, slip him a manual."

"Secret martial arts? A manual?"

For a moment, Mungyeong doubted his own ears.

An individual's or sect's secret martial arts were the crystallized essence of everything they had learned. They could not be taught even for ten thousand pieces of gold and were more precious than life itself.

Yet Jeok Cheongang was telling him to teach those secret arts to someone else's Disciple.

Mungyeong asked with complete sincerity.

“…Have you gone senile and forgotten what secret martial arts are?”

“I know exactly what they are. Unless you plan on saving them to wipe your ass with, teach him a few.”

“You lunatic.”

“You don’t have anyone else to teach them to anyway. Let your old Disciple in Sichuan keep saving lives, and teach our boy how to kill properly.”

Was that something he could say with a straight face?

Mungyeong was too dumbfounded to speak. Meanwhile, having said everything he wanted to say, Jeok Cheongang was already speeding away into the distance.

Whoosh!

“What a… fucking mess.”

Chapter 487

After confirming the Gate's existence, my thoughts had been a mess, but Jeok Cheongang's help had cleared them right up.

"…"

Actually, screw that. It wasn't help. He had beaten me so thoroughly that every joint in my body ached.

When I ran into Hyuk Mujin later, he saw me groaning and gave me a thumbs-up.

"Wow, as expected of you, Captain! You can still get back up after taking that kind of beating!"

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Put that thumb away while I'm still asking nicely. Before I pound the top of your head and turn you into Thumb Princess.[2302]"

With my Strength, I could totally pull off a compression press.

He might not have known exactly what a Thumb Princess was, but the murderous atmosphere had clearly gotten through to him.

Hyuk Mujin hastily lowered his thumb and muttered, "He's always picking on me. If only he'd stayed laid up with his injuries…"

"Mujin, what did you say?"

"I was saying that the Captain has risen rapidly to become a Morning Star of the Murim!"

"…"

Now that was a heartfelt lie.

It would not be an exaggeration to say he had elevated quick thinking to the realm of art. Feeling a sudden pang of pity, I patted Hyuk Mujin on the shoulder.

"Yeah. You hang in there too. You've been shooting up lately."

"Me?"

"Yeah. I heard it in the marketplace on the way here."

Hyuk Mujin might be treated like a nobody here, but he was a martial artist who had earned the impressive sobriquet Swift Wind Sword after helping the Jin Family of Taiyuan pacify northern Gaoyuan.

And since he was always walking around with a blue-chip stock like me, his own stock had naturally begun to rise as well.

"Listening to the townspeople talk, you sounded like some battle-hardened veteran."

"Ahem. Is that so?"

[2302] "Thumb Princess" is the Korean title for *Thumbelina*, the fairy tale about a tiny girl.

"Yeah. At least a Supreme Peak master. If that isn't shooting up, what is?"

Hyuk Mujin had been grinning happily, but now he looked me up and down suspiciously.

"What's with that disrespectful look?"

"I thought you might say I'd shot up, then hit me and leave me laid up."

"…You crazy bastard."

It was a decent scenario, though. Still, was my image really that bad?

Come to think of it, I have beaten him quite a lot.

I suddenly felt sorry for him. How many times had he been hit to develop this much of a persecution complex?

I gazed at Hyuk Mujin with pity, let out a deep sigh, and said, "No. I told you, I heard it in the marketplace myself."

"Really? You swear on everything?"

"I stake both your balls on it."

"Oh. I guess it must be true, then. At last, the fame of the Jin Family's prodigy, the Swift Wind Sword Hyuk Mujin, has spread throughout the Murim—"

Hyuk Mujin, who had been grinning from ear to ear, suddenly stopped.

"Wait a minute. Something feels wrong."

"What?"

"Why are you staking my balls?"

I answered calmly.

"Because they're your balls, obviously."

"What? Why is that obvious?"

"Because you're Hyuk Mujin."

"What the hell does that even mean…"

His expression was a sight to behold.

If I lost every single one of the countless bets I had made involving Hyuk Mujin, saying that even thirty balls wouldn't be enough would hardly be an exaggeration. There was no need to spell that out.

"Ever thought about cutting one off and planting it? A tree might grow."

"Plant what?"

"What else?"

Hyuk Mujin followed my gaze and stared at me like I was a lunatic.

"I've never heard of a tree like that."

"That's why you'd be the first."

"I'll leave that honor to you, Captain."

"Enough. What were you doing that you only showed up now? You were nowhere to be seen earlier."

Immediately after the Water God Dragon fell, we had split into two groups. Cheongpung and Hyuk Mujin had followed Zhuge Feng, so this was the first time I had seen them in exactly two days.

At my question, Hyuk Mujin shook the net he was holding.

“What’s that?”

“Fish. I’ve been capturing them.”

“Fish?”

“Yes. I’ve been catching them since yesterday, but it hasn’t been easy.”

Right. Of course. Catching fish must be so hard.

I looked back and forth between Hyuk Mujin and the net full of thrashing fish, then nodded faintly.

“I see. Our Mujin was busy fishing.”

“I’m not joking. These things are so violent and strong that they’ve nearly drained me dry—”

Smack!

“Gah!”

“Drained you dry? You abandoned your direct superior, the man you’re supposed to serve with undying loyalty, and came here to enjoy a little fishing? Just looking at you is draining me dry!”

Hyuk Mujin staggered backward, clutching his head, then shouted furiously, “That’s not what you think!”

“You dare raise your voice at me? You said you were catching fish, didn’t you?”

“It wasn’t fishing! It was capturing! Capturing!”

“Capturing? Cheongpung, capture this bastard!”

“Ah! Yes, Benefactor!”

Cheongpung, who had been lingering nearby, rushed over and seized Hyuk Mujin.

How could Hyuk Mujin possibly resist the grappling technique of Huashan’s Morning Star, a Supreme Peak master who had inherited the Sword Saint’s legacy?

I looked down at the helplessly subdued Hyuk Mujin and solemnly declared, “Even if the Murim perishes tomorrow, I shall plant a single testicle tree.”

“Wait. Wait!”

“I ask you: Is the left ball yours, or the right?”

“They’re both mine! What kind of bullshit is that?”

“You’re an honest fellow. As a reward, I’ll take both.”

“Let go! I said let go! You crazy bastards!”

Just then, as Hyuk Mujin’s screams rang through the air—

Hiss!

“If we bury them somewhere sunny, they’ll grow nice and strong… Whoa, that startled me.”

It happened in an instant.

Something long and pure white shot out of Cheongpung’s arms like a streak of light. Cheongpung immediately sprang to his feet, releasing Hyuk Mujin.

“Where are you going, Mimi?”

“Phew!”

Finally freed from Cheongpung’s hold, Hyuk Mujin pointed at the net he had dropped and shouted, “Capture! Not fishing—capture! See for yourself!”

As it turned out, Hyuk Mujin’s protests were pointless.

The moment Mimi sprang from Cheongpung’s arms and darted toward the net, my gaze had already locked onto her.

And as soon as I saw the scene unfolding before me, a single thought crossed my mind.

Just one problem after another.

Hiss! Chomp!

Flicking her tongue, Mimi slipped between the gaps in the net and tore into one of the fish’s gills.

Though I wasn’t sure that thing should even be called a fish.

Thud! Flap-flap!

Its eyes were bright blood-red. Its teeth were sharp as saw blades, and its body was larger than an adult man’s forearm.

And on its tail… Fuck. What the hell was that?

I stared in disbelief and muttered, “…A spike?”

Hyuk Mujin, who had gotten to his feet while panting, answered gruffly, “You may be hard of hearing when people talk, but your eyesight is excellent.”

“What kind of fish has a spike on its tail?”

“Maybe it’s a special weapon.”

“…Are you going to keep talking bullshit?”

“I told you, didn’t I? Fishing, my ass. It was capturing. Capturing! How could you catch something like that with a fishing rod?”

“Huh.”

Capture. Now that I heard it again, there really was no better word for catching something like that.

Grumbling to himself, Hyuk Mujin walked over and picked up the net he had dropped. Only then did I realize it wasn’t an ordinary net, but a heavy mesh woven from iron and steel.

“What the hell is that?”

“As you can see, their teeth are incredibly sharp. One bite would tear through an ordinary net—”

“I’m not talking about the net. What are those things inside it?”

“Oh.”

Clang!

Hyuk Mujin frowned at the creatures thrashing violently enough to nearly tear the metal mesh apart.

“For now, everyone calls them Blood Fish.”

“Blood Fish?”

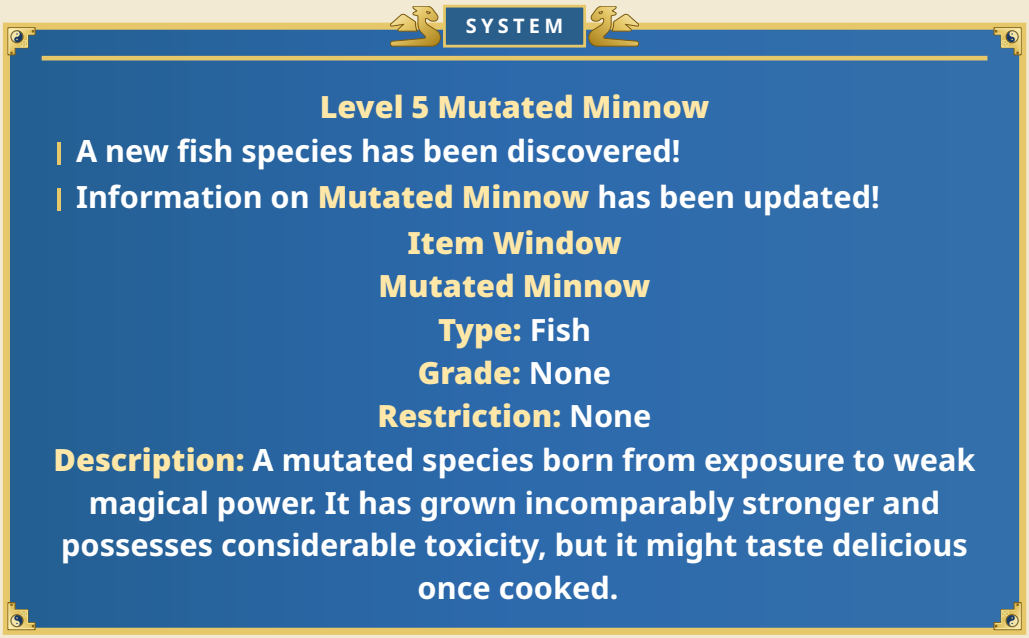
“Yes. Because their eyes are blood-red.”

Blood Fish. It was certainly a fitting name for their sinister appearance. But I wanted to know the exact name of these grotesque creatures.

Qi Sense.

Whoosh… Beep.

The wave of Qi Sense spread outward from me and reached them. A System notification appeared, and Level windows rose above their massive bodies.



“…”

This is a minnow?

I stared at the thing, which was larger than an ordinary adult man’s forearm.

What happened to the minnows I know?

They might as well tell me this isn’t Dongting Lake but the Amazon.

First, I was shocked that this monster of a fish was Level 5. Then I was shocked all over again by the System window’s bullshit claim that it was incredibly strong and poisonous but might taste good.

It might taste good once cooked? You just said it was poisonous, you crazy bastards. Still, there could only be one cause.

This transformation had undoubtedly been caused by the magical power leaking from the Gate.

The Water God Dragon had sacrificed itself to absorb most of the Gate's magical power, but it couldn't have done anything about the residue.

And from what I had personally confirmed just one or two shichen[2303] ago, the Gate was still leaking a faint trace of magical power despite having ceased to function.

What happens if things like these spread throughout the world? What if it's contagious?

I already knew the answer.

We'd be fucked. That's what.

The tributaries of Dongting Lake flowed into the Yangtze, and the Yangtze was both a vast natural ecosystem and a waterway traveled by countless people.

I wasn't part of some environmental organization, so the destruction of the ecosystem was a secondary concern. But if some infectious agent caused mutated creatures to flood onto land, then it would be the end of everything.

"…This is driving me insane."

"What's wrong?"

"Benefactor, are you all right?"

"No. Not even a little."

I answered firmly and turned toward Cheongpung.

"Cheongpung, how many of these things are there?"

"I wasn't assigned to this area, so I don't know. But Mimi likes them. They must taste good!"

Cheongpung gazed adoringly at Mimi, who had already swallowed a Blood Fish several times larger than her own body.

"Eat lots, Mimi!"

"…Right. Asking you makes me the idiot. Then, Mujin."

"Yes. We've captured around a hundred Blood Fish so far, but we haven't determined how many more there are."

I never knew the presence of a normal person could be this comforting.

I looked at Hyuk Mujin with deep emotion and asked, "Great Hero Zhuge Feng knows about this too?"

"Of course. As soon as the Blood Fish were discovered, Great Hero Zhuge Feng ordered the waterway at the entrance completely sealed off."

[2303] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"What about the Blood Fish that already escaped?"

"Well, for now, it seems there were hardly any."

"What?"

According to the past I had glimpsed through the *Memory Fragment*, the Gate had opened at least a month ago.

Judging by the fact that it was still leaking faint magical power, a considerable number of fish should have mutated by now…

"Are you sure?"

"It's just a guess, but they were fighting one another."

"Fighting?"

"They've become so ferocious that they seem to have lost any concept of allies. They're probably still killing one another right now."

"…"

Should I be happy about this or not?

Their ferocity made them dangerous, but since they had started a war among themselves and were reducing their own numbers, it was certainly something to celebrate.

At least that's a relief.

I had just let out a sigh of relief when—

"There you are, Young Master Jin."

A clear, infuriatingly sweet voice came from behind me.

When I turned, Mungyeong was already standing there, looking at me.

"They're looking for you."

"I'm busy. The grown-ups are working, so wait."

"…I was told to bring you no matter what. They have something to say to you."

"Who?"

A murderous Sound Transmission bored into my ear.

Me.

"…Oh."

Then I had better go.

Chapter 488

The Water God Dragon had unquestionably been a spiritual being.

In the broadest sense, it could be called a spiritual creature. But it possessed power far beyond that of an ordinary spiritual creature, which was probably why it had been able to absorb all the magical power from the Gate.

You could tell just by looking at the weather.

As expected of an imugi[2304] that had lived for five hundred years, there was something different about it.

When the mutated Water God Dragon had gone on a rampage, thunderbolts and towering waves had nearly turned Dongting Lake upside down. Now, however, the lake was calm, as though nothing had ever happened.

But unlike the peaceful waters of Dongting Lake, a raging storm churned inside me.

…Is this what they call the calm before the storm?

I glanced at Mungyeong's back as he walked ahead of me.

He was a head shorter than me, with a slender frame. But beneath the hide of a harmless herbivore lurked a predator.

Why did he suddenly call me out here? What could he possibly want to say?

I suddenly felt wronged.

Could he still be pissed because I'd spoken casually to him during the battle?

He hadn't called me out here just so we could have a little physical conversation, had he?

My unease continued to grow as Mungyeong led me deeper into increasingly secluded territory.

That was when—

"Stop."

Whoosh!

There was only one voice, but seven figures surrounded us.

They were all Peak masters who had accumulated considerable internal energy, and each wore a sword engraved with a pine pattern at his waist.

Pine-Pattern Ancient Swords.

Sure enough, a middle-aged Daoist dressed in Wudang robes emerged from the deep darkness.

Judging by his age, the middle-aged Daoist was clearly their presiding chair. He opened his mouth toward us.

[2304] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent associated with dragons.

"This area is closed after the Hour of the Dog.[2305] Please turn back—No, wait. Could that be the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon?"

"What?"

The middle-aged Daoist spotted me over Mungyeong's shoulder and asked with wide eyes,

"Young Hero Jin Taekyung? No, Great Hero Jin Taekyung?"

"I'm no Great Hero, but my name is Jin Taekyung."

"Oh! My guess was correct after all. I thought your face looked familiar."

You may recognize me, but you're a complete stranger to me.

The middle-aged Daoist greeted me as warmly as if I were his son fresh out of the army. Then, as if something had suddenly occurred to him, he asked, "But what brings you here at this late hour? You must have already been assigned temporary lodgings."

"…Uh. Well."

I was being dragged away by the Slaughter Saint.

I swallowed the words rising to my throat and was about to offer some vague excuse when a flash of insight struck me.

Come to think of it, this was my last God-given chance to escape.

"Is this where the restricted area begins?"

"That's right. We take turns standing watch in case of an emergency. But who is this young-looking man with you?"

"Slaugh—"

"Hm?"

—Instant execution.

"—The breeze is blowing softly."

"Oh, ha ha. I see."

Slaughter Saint! Mister! That bastard is the Slaughter Saint!

I finally understood how the barber who shouted that the king had donkey ears must have felt.

But when I met the beast's dark, sunken gaze, I forced a smile and answered, "We just happened to get to know each other."

"If you know each other, then precisely what kind of—"

"We met in Sichuan and have been traveling together ever since. He isn't a martial artist. He's a medical apprentice."

"Ah, now I remember. I heard there was a young medical apprentice with the skills of a renowned physician. So this is him."

"Yes. He's the one."

[2305] The Hour of the Dog is a traditional time period corresponding to approximately 7–9 p.m.

"But why have you come all the way out here at such a late hour?"

"Uh, we have something important to discuss."

"You must be quite close."

I could let everything else slide, but not that.

I answered with a straight face.

"No. We're not close."

"Hm. In that case, I'm afraid this may be difficult. My apologies, Great Hero Jin, but regulations prohibit us from allowing anyone through without firm assurance—"

"Ah, I see. Thank you for your hard work. Mungyeong, let's go!"

—Instant execution.

"…"

—Back in position.

The icy Sound Transmission stabbed into me.

I had already turned halfway around, but I helplessly turned back.

—Say we're close.

"I was joking. We're actually very close."

The middle-aged Daoist looked back and forth between Mungyeong and me, then muttered, "For two people who are supposedly close, you were walking apart without saying a word…"

—Answer properly.

"We're so close that we can understand each other just by looking into each other's eyes."

"But your head was turned away. How could you see his eyes…?"

"We used to understand each other just by looking into each other's eyes. These days, I can tell what he's thinking just by looking at the back of his head."

"…"

—I'm asking this out of genuine curiosity. Does the Fire Gate Clan have a rule saying it should recruit only fucking idiots?

For fuck's sake. What do you want me to do?

As the middle-aged Daoist stared at me with lukewarm eyes, Mungyeong's Sound Transmission continued.

—Come closer.

"…?"

—Put your arm around my shoulder.

"…!"

What am I, some kind of avatar?

But what could I do? In the Murim, the strong were the law—and the gods.

I trudged over, draped an arm around Mungyeong's shoulders, and pulled a miserable face.

"Whew. We're really close."

—Smile.

"Ha ha ha! We're really close!"

—Louder.

"Wahahahahaha!"

—I can see you signaling with the corner of your eye. Do that one more time, and I'll make you see the world with your heart instead of your eyes.

He had found a remarkably elegant way to say he would gouge out my eyes.

I gave up my desperate attempts to signal with sidelong glances and muttered, "Anyway, we're close."

Throughout this entire exchange, the Wudang martial artists—including the middle-aged Daoist—stared at us as though they were watching the best horror movie of the summer.

I had gone from looking miserable to laughing like a lunatic, all while frantically shooting Mungyeong sidelong glances. If they couldn't tell something was wrong, they needed to put down their Pine-Pattern Ancient Swords and leave Wudang.

At last, the middle-aged Daoist seemed to make up his mind. His lips moved.

—Perhaps I'm worrying over nothing, but if something is happening to you without your realizing it, blink three times. If nothing is wrong, blink twice.

—I heard everything. Blink three times, and your body will be cut into three pieces.

Mister! You bastard! This bastard is the Slaughter Saint! This bastard has a wiretap in his ear!

But my shout never escaped, and I quietly blinked twice.

No matter how suspicious they became, they would never guess that the young medical apprentice before them was a Supreme Peak master who had Returned to Youth.

And objectively speaking, the Slaughter Saint was clearly an ally.

—Are you sure?

Even if he asked, my answer had already been decided.

Even among Supreme Peak masters, Jeok Cheongang and the Slaughter Saint had reached a different depth of enlightenment. They were biological wiretaps capable of eavesdropping on other people's Sound Transmissions.

—Yes. Why would I lie about something like this? We're just friends who became close while traveling together.

Though one of us seemed to have built up murderous intent instead of friendship.

Still, something had been built.

The middle-aged Daoist let out a quiet snort of laughter after hearing my Sound Transmission.

—Indeed. How could anything happen to the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon of all people? Great Hero Jin, please forgive me for being so suspicious. I suppose the recent events have made me more sensitive than usual.

No, you're insensitive. Please get just a little more sensitive.

But contrary to my hopes, the middle-aged Daoist spoke with a warm smile.

"In that case, very well. If it's Great Hero Jin and no one else, I can trust you. You may pass!"

"W-Wait a moment."

"Ha ha. I wondered why you had come all the way out here, but it seems you truly do have something important to discuss. Very well. Regulations prohibit this, but… I'll give you some privacy."

"What?"

"About half an hour. Will that be enough?"

Of course it won't, you idiot. Enough for what?

But before I could answer, Mungyeong bowed politely with a bright smile.

"That will be sufficient."

"…!"

Why did that brief answer sound like a death threat to me?

The middle-aged Daoist failed to notice my twitching eyelids. He stroked his beard and smiled approvingly.

"What a polite young man. You should examine me sometime as well."

"Of course, Daoist."

"Ha ha. Then I'll return in half an hour."

Whoosh!

The seven Peak masters—including the middle-aged Daoist—or rather, the seven witnesses, shot away.

I stared blankly at their backs as they vanished into the distance. Then I slowly turned around, feeling a curtain of qi close around us from every direction.

Sound and impact.

Everything was now sealed off from the outside world by the qi barrier surrounding us.

And within that space, a pair of eyes gleamed with an icy light even in the darkness.

"Master and Disciple are exactly alike when it comes to wearing people out."

"…!"

The voice alone sent a chill through my chest.

The young man who had seemed like an innocent medical apprentice had transformed into the greatest assassin of all time. He leaned against a large rock.

He gave off no ripple of qi, but I could still feel them—the countless blades concealed throughout his body.

The Slaughter Saint.

This was Mungyeong's hidden name and his true nature.

I didn't know what he had been like in the past. But I would stake Hyuk Mujin's balls on this: even after some forty years away from the Murim, Mungyeong's blades had not dulled in the slightest.

No. If anything, they had undoubtedly grown even sharper.

Ah. I miss Mom.

I knew Mungyeong wouldn't actually harm me.

But the head and the heart often thought differently.

Even if you knew the beast before you wasn't about to sink its teeth into your throat, that didn't mean you wanted to approach it.

Gulp.

I swallowed dryly and cautiously opened my mouth.

"Why did you suddenly…?"

Mungyeong stared at me with icy eyes.

"You sound as though you resent being called out here."

"Gasp. No, I don't."

"You certainly seem to."

"How could I? I'm simply bad at expressing my emotions. The truth is, I'm so happy I could die."

"Die?"

"…I'll carefully take those two words back. I should've watched my mouth. I really don't learn until there's a coffin in front of me."

"See a coffin?"

"…Please spare me."

"Spare you?"

Goddamn it.

I'd read online that repeating the last thing a woman said was the kind of conversational technique that made her heart flutter.

This was the kind of conversation that would make the Grim Reaper's heart flutter.

I could almost see Yama, who had just clocked out on time, excitedly rushing back with the Book of Life and Death in hand.

Seriously, what the hell is this? Why did he call me out here?

Had he really called me here again because I had spoken casually to him last time?

If I knew what this was about, I could at least put my mind at ease. But I couldn't think of any other reason, and the frustration was driving me insane.

Mungyeong regarded me with displeasure, then suddenly furrowed his brow.

"What is this?"

"What?"

"Have you perhaps not heard yet?"

"Heard what?"

"The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. Your Master."

"…?"

"The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang."

So what am I supposed to do with that?

I had no idea what he meant, so I didn't even know how to respond.

After hesitating for a moment, I cautiously ventured a guess.

"Ganggangsullae?"[2306]

"Jeok Cheongang didn't tell you any—What?"

"Oh, isn't this a word-chain game?"

"…What kind of lunatic are you?"

"Or is there a character limit? But 'Fire King Jeok Cheongang' is five characters in Korean too, so it should be fine…"

The atmosphere turned ominous.

Mungyeong stared at me with eyes full of anger and regret, then looked up at the heavens and sighed.

"I can't believe I have to pass down my secret martial arts to a fucking blockhead like this."

"…"

For fuck's sake. Even so, calling someone a blockhead right to his face was too much. That was going too far…

Huh?

What did I just hear?

Secret martial arts?

[2306] *Ganggangsullae* is a traditional Korean circle dance and folk song. Taekyung treats the last syllable of Jeok Cheongang's name as the start of a word-chain answer.

Chapter 489

Secret martial arts.

The moment I heard those words, the four syllables *fucking blockhead* vanished cleanly from my mind.

I blinked for a moment, then stammered,

“Secret… martial arts? You’re saying you’ll teach me your secret martial arts?”

To a martial artist, secret martial arts were as important as life itself—no, more important than life.

Even in martial arts novels, people willing to throw themselves into danger like moths to a flame just to obtain a single martial arts manual were everywhere.

And after experiencing the Murim firsthand, I’d learned that reality was no different. If anything, it was worse.

But he’s offering to teach me his secret martial arts? An incredible master like the Slaughter Saint?

Even though I’d heard it straight from him, I couldn’t believe it. More importantly, there was one enormous question hanging over the whole thing.

“Why?”

A deep furrow formed between Mungyeong’s smooth brows at my doubtful question.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean, why are you suddenly doing this for me?”

“I suspected as much, but it seems the Fire King, that old man, truly didn’t give you any warning.”

“Then could it be…”

“That’s right. Your guess is correct. The Fire King…”

“Am I being transferred? Have I gone from the Fire Gate Clan to the Slaughter Saint Clan or something?”

“…”

Mungyeong stared at me as though he badly wanted to kill someone, then continued with a sigh.

“The Fire King came to me personally and asked me to teach you martial arts.”

“What?”

It was a relief that this wasn’t some sect-to-sect trade, but this was just as hard to believe.

I eyed Mungyeong suspiciously.

“What is that look?”

“No matter how I think about it, this sounds like a lie.”

“A lie?”

“First, our Old Master has a foul temper and far too much pride to ask anyone for anything.”

A warm glow passed over Mungyeong’s face, which had previously been surrounded by a chilly aura.

“Hm. You’ve assessed him rather accurately. Continue.”

“Second, the person he asked is just as foul-tempered and prideful as our Old Master, so he would never willingly teach anyone his secret martial arts.”

“…”

“So, for those two reasons, I wouldn’t believe this even with a knife to my throat.”

“I see. So that’s how it is.”

Mungyeong murmured softly and fixed me with an icy stare.

“If a knife were at your throat, you would believe me. I heard you clearly.”

At that moment, something glinted at the edge of Mungyeong’s sleeve. The instant I saw the short sword slowly emerging, I quietly changed my tune.

“I completely believe you now.”

“Suddenly?”

“Actually, I’ve firmly believed you from the very beginning.”

“You fucking lunatic. Is there something wrong with your personality?”

“Gah!”

“You truly are insane beyond all reason.”

Ah, he just wants to kill me.

It was written all over his face.

Mungyeong toyed with the short sword for a moment, conflict in his eyes, then abruptly spoke.

“Come to think of it, you weren’t entirely wrong.”

“What?”

“First, as you said, the Fire King does have a foul temper and excessive pride. But matters concerning his Disciple seem to be the one exception.”

“…!”

“Of course, even after hearing that, he would stubbornly insist that you aren’t his formal Disciple. Regardless, the Fire King cares about you. Very much.”

Hmm.

I didn’t know what to say. Something tickled deep in my chest, and my throat felt tight.

It just… did.

As I kept my lips firmly sealed, Mungyeong continued in a dry voice.

“Second, I’m hardly a man of gentle temperament myself. But given sufficient reason, I would be willing to teach my secret martial arts even to a lunatic like you.”

“Even though I’m a lunatic?”

“Because that lunatic will become a major obstacle to Dark Heaven’s actions from this point forward.”

His quiet voice drifted through the night air. Mungyeong gazed at the gently flowing waters of Dongting Lake as he continued.

“I have lived as a martial artist for more than half my life. No, as an assassin. It was not a life I chose, but one imposed on me from the beginning. That is why the path I walked was a bloody road strewn with blood and corpses.”

The Slaughter Saint. A sobriquet proclaiming him the greatest assassin in history was not something he had earned overnight. He had killed, killed, and killed again until he finally reached a position that everyone had no choice but to acknowledge and fear.

But everyone had their circumstances.

And there were far more secrets in this world than I knew. Mungyeong must have lived a life steeped in them.

With emotions I couldn’t decipher mingling in his eyes, Mungyeong stared into the darkness and continued quietly.

“If passing on my martial arts to you can be of even the slightest help in the great war already at our doorstep, then it doesn’t seem like such a bad idea. That is all.”

He spoke as though it were nothing, but it couldn’t have been an easy decision.

Receiving what belonged to someone else was easy. Giving away what was yours was hard.

If everyone who had fought in the Great Faction War had thought and acted as Mungyeong did now, half the martial artists in the world would have learned the martial arts of the Nine Sects and One Gang[2307] by now.

Seeing him in that light made Mungyeong seem like a different person.

“Is that… what they call serving a greater cause?”

“A greater cause?”

“You made this decision for other people. Sacrificing yourself for others—isn’t that what serving a greater cause means?”

Mungyeong shook his head.

“A greater cause is not something a man like me can speak of. An assassin who once killed others to survive, talking of a greater cause? The very thought makes me cringe.”

[2307] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a traditional grouping of major martial-arts factions: nine sects and the Beggars’ Gang.

“The Old Master once told me that the Slaughter Saint only kills people who deserve it. He said you were a fairly decent assassin.”

“To make a single sword, you must hammer it hundreds of times and put it through the tempering process. I was no different. Before I became the Slaughter Saint, there was a time when I was called the Killing Ghost. That is why I cannot discuss a great cause.”

“In that case…”

I looked Mungyeong straight in the eye.

“What about the greater cause you serve as the Divine Physician, rather than the Slaughter Saint?”

“…!”

His slender body suddenly went rigid.

The waters of Dongting Lake remained utterly still, but ripples stirred in Mungyeong’s eyes.

A moment later, his low, somber voice broke the brief silence.

“The Divine Physician… I never liked that sobriquet.”

“Why not?”

“Being called the Divine Physician does not erase my past. I know that if the truth came to light, those people would curse and fear me.”

“But you saved them. More people than anyone could count. They won’t forget what you did for them.”

A long time passed without an answer.

Mungyeong remained lost in thought, silently watching the water. Then he suddenly whipped his head around to face me.

“Gasp! You scared me. What’s wrong?”

“I was considering what to do with you for daring to speak so presumptuously to me.”

“…Wouldn’t most people call that comforting someone?”

“Comforting me? You?”

His icy gaze was refreshing enough to cool my internal organs.

Yeah, fuck. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon or whatever—to the Slaughter Saint, I’m still just some nobody.

Rather than talk back and get hit by the backlash, changing the subject was probably the secret to a long life.

“Wow, the moon is bright tonight.”

Mungyeong’s eyebrow twitched as I immediately pretended nothing had happened.

“I don’t know how the conversation wandered this far. Refrain from such pointless words and actions in the future.”

“The breeze is nice and cool, too.”

“Want me to cool off everything above your shoulders too?”

“…I’ll take what you just said to heart.”

Shhk.

The half-drawn short sword slid back into his sleeve.

As though nothing had happened, Mungyeong returned to his usual dry, rigid expression.

“So I’ll ask you. What do you intend to do?”

“About what?”

“I can’t tell whether you’re stupid or hard of hearing. I’m talking about learning martial arts from me.”

“…I’m not stupid. I just didn’t expect you to give me a choice.”

“Why would I force someone who doesn’t wish to learn to stay and teach him?”

He had a point, but hearing such a perfectly normal statement from such an abnormal person felt incredibly strange.

Of course, I didn’t say that aloud.

If I did, Mungyeong would personally drag my soul out of my body.

“So? What is your answer?”

At Mungyeong’s urging, I scratched the back of my head.

The Slaughter Saint’s secret martial arts…

Of course I wanted to learn them.

Everyone had martial arts that suited them, and an ill-suited martial art could do more harm than good. But these were the secret martial arts of the Slaughter Saint, a Supreme Peak master counted among the greatest in the world.

If I could understand even half—no, even a quarter—of the insights contained in his martial arts and make them my own, my realm might advance another step.

There was only one thing bothering me.

“It seems the Fire King is weighing on your mind.”

“…Have you learned mind-reading or something?”

“What need is there for mind-reading? Every thought in your head shows plainly on your face.”

Mungyeong looked at me as though I were hopeless and continued.

“A proper martial artist must know how to conceal his thoughts. The Fire King is unbelievable. To think he failed to teach you even something so basic.”

“Take that back.”

At my frown, Mungyeong’s gaze grew heavy.

“Was I wrong?”

“Yes. Even if your mouth is crooked, you should still speak straight.”

“You dare…”

“He didn’t fail to teach me. He couldn’t. The Old Master is even worse at hiding his expressions than I am, so how could he teach me something he doesn’t know?”

“…You exceed even my wildest expectations.”

Mungyeong sighed and shook his head.

“In any case, don’t concern yourself too much with the Fire King. He personally asked this of me, and I have no intention whatsoever of entering into a Master-Disciple relationship with someone like you.”

“Ah. Right.”

Come on. Even so, someone like you?

It stung a little, but Mungyeong’s firm declaration still put me much more at ease.

Then why do I feel like I’m betraying the Old Master?

Jeok Cheongang himself had asked Mungyeong to do this, and considering the brutal battles ahead, the training would only help me.

There was nothing wrong with it when I considered the circumstances, so why did it still leave such a bad taste in my mouth?

Thinking of Jeok Cheongang, who had disappeared without a word, I smacked my lips and finally nodded.

“All right.”

“Think carefully before you answer. Starting is your choice. Stopping will not be.”

“What? What does that mean?”

“From that point on, you will move solely according to my judgment. But if you complete this training, you will emerge a different martial artist than you were before.”

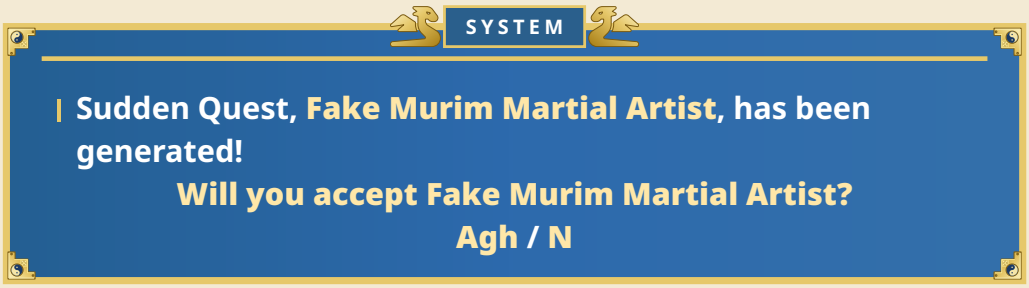
What was this?

I’d expected something along those lines, considering who I would be learning from, but a chill still crept down my spine.

I swallowed dryly. Then, alongside Mungyeong’s rigid voice, a familiar chime rang in my ears.

“You may have reached a considerable realm as a martial artist, but being a martial artist and being a martial artist of the Murim are not the same. You’re still only half-formed. I will make you a true Murim martial artist.”

Ding.



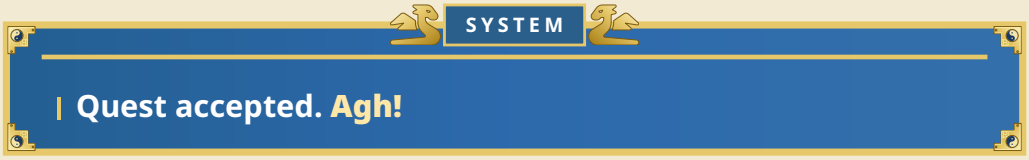
"…"

Why was there an Agh instead of a Y among the choices?

I stared incredulously at the Quest window, then muttered before I could stop myself.

"Agh?"

Ding.



"…Ah."

This was driving me crazy.

Chapter 490

“So, did you finish your conversation?”

The Wudang Daoists returned exactly half an hour later, just as they had said they would.

I still had plenty of questions, and I wanted to move somewhere else and keep talking. Mungyeong, however, had other ideas.

“We’re done. Go back.”

“…What? We’re done? You haven’t even told me what kind of training this is!”

“You’ll naturally find out tomorrow.”

“It’s already the hour of the Pig.[2308] It’ll be midnight soon. Can’t you just tell me and get it over with?”

“It’s late. Don’t forget. We begin tomorrow.”

“No, hold on. Excuse me.”

“Excuse you?”

Shhk.

I looked back and forth between Mungyeong and the short sword peeking out from his sleeve, then stiffly pointed beyond him into the darkness.

“I meant over there. That’s the way you should go.”

“…”

“Just keep going straight, then turn right.”

“It seems that wasn’t what you were trying to say.”

“I thought you might not know the way, so I figured I’d better make sure. Hehe.”

“I know. Shut up and get lost.”

“Yes, sir. Have a peaceful night.”

A little while later, after confirming that Mungyeong’s back had completely disappeared from sight, I muttered under my breath.

“Goddammit…”

It was one problem after another.

Just when I thought I had finally gotten used to Jeok Cheongang’s methods, now I had to start worrying about the Slaughter Saint’s mood too.

My eyes were already going dark just thinking about the hardships waiting ahead.

Actually, the Old Master is much better.

Leaving aside the intensity of his training, Jeok Cheongang at least told me what kind of training I would be doing.

His temper might have been as hot as fire, but he had still prepared something resembling a curriculum.

[2308] The hour of the Pig corresponds roughly to 9–11 p.m. in traditional East Asian timekeeping.

But what kind of training is so secret that he won't even tell me?

There was a simple reason I was so curious. The Quest I had accepted by accident didn't contain any real information either.

Quest window, open.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Fake Murim Martial Artist
Sensing the war clouds that will soon gather over the world, Mungyeong has decided after careful consideration to teach you personally.
However, all things require preparation.
Before passing down his secret martial arts, Mungyeong will test you in various ways.
When this first test ends is up to you.
Grade: None
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Earn Mungyeong's recognition *(Incomplete)*
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

I looked over the Quest window two or three more times, but it remained unchanged.

Compared to the training Quest at Mount Jiuhua, where the objective had been clearly stated, this was nothing but vague nonsense.

Earn Mungyeong's recognition.

At this point, I would rather run around with iron balls hanging from me. At least then I would have a clear objective and be able to check my progress.

But this was basically the crime of getting on someone's bad side.

Didn't it mean I had to keep getting put through the wringer until he decided he liked me?

This feels like it'll take a while.

I didn't know what Mungyeong's training methods would be like, but one thing was certain: earning his recognition wouldn't be easy.

Objectively speaking, it would be strange if it were.

It's probably going to be brutal, but I'll have to endure it.

The man I was dealing with wasn't some ordinary martial artist. He was the Slaughter Saint, a Supreme Peak master counted among the greatest in the world.

Being taught secret martial arts by someone of that caliber was a fortuitous encounter in itself.

And when I thought about it, I had already experienced two such fortuitous encounters.

The first was, without a doubt, the System.

And the second…

The Old Master.

There was no way I could leave Jeok Cheongang out of it.

If I hadn't met him—if I hadn't learned the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts, passed down to only one person in each generation—then even with the System, I probably wouldn't have attained my current strength or position.

As that train of thought continued, Jeok Cheongang's face suddenly flashed through my mind.

Still, I should go see him.

Of course, Jeok Cheongang and I had never formally entered into a Master-Disciple relationship.

But just because we didn't call each other Master and Disciple didn't mean ours was merely a relationship of convenience.

We were the kind of people who understood each other without speaking. Jeok Cheongang and I quietly turned the words *Master* and *Disciple* over in our hearts.

"…"

Or maybe not. I'm suddenly not so sure.

Jeok Cheongang might think differently, but that was how I saw it.

And it was obvious that Jeok Cheongang must be troubled after swallowing his pride and personally asking Mungyeong to teach someone who was practically his Disciple.

He's probably off somewhere moping by himself again.

Other people whispered that Jeok Cheongang was nothing more than a hot-tempered, impossibly eccentric old man. But the Jeok Cheongang I knew was tenderhearted.

He might scold and grumble, but beneath it all, his heart was practically soggy with affection for the people he cared about.

I glanced up at the bright moon and started walking.

I'll find him soon enough. There are plenty of people around.

That comfortable thought vanished without a trace less than half an hour later.

"You haven't seen him?"

"No, sir. I haven't seen him for a while."

"If you're lying to me…"

“Why would I lie to the Captain? If I didn’t want to get beaten to death, I’d make up things that never happened and tell you.”

“Cheongpung? You haven’t seen him either?”

“No, Benefactor. Why? Is something wrong?”

“It’s… Never mind. It’s nothing. Get back to what you were doing.”

“Oh! If nothing’s wrong, would you like to see Mimi? She ate ten Blood Fish, so her belly is incredibly round!”

“Yeah. Great.”

This place wasn’t even that large. Where on earth had he disappeared to?

I searched everywhere for the missing Jeok Cheongang, but no matter whom I stopped and asked, the answers were never helpful.

“Hey, you beggar passing by. Come here.”

“No.”

“You haven’t been beaten enough lately.”

“Damn it. I have a reputation to maintain too. No matter how much of a Supreme Peak master you are, if you treat me, the Successor Beggar, like some stray dog you’re calling over from the street, what will the Sect’s disciples think?”

“Two silver nyang.[2309]”

“Are you seriously treating me like a beggar…”

“Ten nyang.[2310]”

Fwoosh!

“Hm. One cannot ignore a friend’s summons. What is it?”

“Our Old Master—no, our Master. Do you know where he is?”

“Sir Jeok? No idea. I haven’t seen him once since he arrived here.”

“Can you ask the other Beggars’ Sect disciples?”

“Well, we’re all busy with our assigned tasks. Still, you never know. I’ll make a round and let you know if I hear anything.”

“Yeah, thanks.”

“What are friends for?”

“Then get to it.”

“…What about the silver?”

“I’ll pay you later. But if you find my Master’s location, I’ll give you double.”

“T-Twenty nyang![2311] Beggerrr!”

But even Gung Gibang, who had become a slave to capitalism and run off enthusiastically, ultimately failed to find Jeok Cheongang.

[2309] A nyang was a historical unit of currency; these amounts are in silver nyang, not modern won.
[2310] A nyang was a historical unit of currency; these amounts are in silver nyang, not modern won.
[2311] A nyang was a historical unit of currency; these amounts are in silver nyang, not modern won.

I tossed him five silver nyang,[2312] then continued making the rounds. The answers I received were always more or less the same.

"Sir Zhuge, have you perhaps seen my Master?"

"Oh, you came at the perfect time. I'm testing our clan's formation, and I think that with a little more refinement, I can suppress the energy leaking from this fissure __"

"That's great. Good luck."

"Great Hero Jin! I saw him!"

"Really? Where?"

"About two shichen[2313] ago, he was over by the water, beating someone senseless."

"The person getting beaten was me."

"…Ah."

"Great Hero Jin! Great Hero Jin!"

"Yes. You there, with your hand raised. Where did you see him?"

"If you mean Sir Jeok, I haven't seen him."

"No, then why are you—"

"Would you sign this martial robe for me? My son dreams of becoming a fine martial artist like Great Hero Jin. He says he'll have no regrets if he can get your autograph…"

"…What's your son's name?"

"Zhuge Sopyeong. Please write something telling him to practice his martial arts diligently and not be a picky eater. Especially when it comes to green onions."

"Wait. Then may I ask for your autograph too?"

"I got here first. Get in line!"

"What? Why are you suddenly lining up? Move to the back! Don't line up! Ah, this is driving me crazy."

About an hour later, after completing my grand tour, I returned to the temporary private tent that had been set up for me. By then, it was already past midnight.

After signing autographs with inspirational messages for Zhuge Sopyeong, Changwoo, Myoryeong, Jinsu, and the other budding talents, I was completely drained.

"…So where the hell is the Old Master?"

This wasn't even the Liaodong Plain. How could he simply vanish into thin air?

At this point, he had clearly made up his mind to stay hidden. He had probably predicted that I would come looking for him and deliberately disappeared.

I'll be seeing him soon enough anyway. For him to avoid me this much…

He must have been even more troubled than I had imagined.

[2312] A nyang was a historical unit of currency; these amounts are in silver nyang, not modern won.

[2313] A shichen is a traditional East Asian time unit of approximately two hours.

I let out a small sigh, picked up the water pitcher from the wooden table in the corner of the tent, and gulped down the water.

I had been walking around and talking all day, so my throat was parched. But why did the water taste like this?

Did they scoop it straight from the river? It's a little salty.

Even if Murim hadn't suffered from environmental pollution yet, I couldn't help feeling uneasy.

That was when it happened.

Beep.

SYSTEM

You have been poisoned by Potent Paralysis Powder.
Potent Paralysis Powder is a type of anesthetic that clouds the mind and stiffens the body.
You feel your consciousness becoming hazy!
Your Scorching Yang Qi resists the poison!
If you do not take action quickly, the Status condition Full-Body Paralysis will activate!

…?

No, fuck. What the hell was this?

Forgetting that my body was slowly becoming paralyzed, I stared blankly at the System window. Then a brief memory flashed through my mind like lightning.

You'll naturally find out tomorrow.

It's already the hour of the Pig.[2314] It'll be midnight soon. Can't you just tell me and get it over with?

It's late. Don't forget. We begin tomorrow.

"…!"

Mungyeong, you son of a bitch!

My blood seemed to surge backward with rage.

At the same time, the blood carrying the paralysis powder raced through my body, and my vision began to fade.

I sucked in a startled breath, hurriedly raised my internal energy, and shouted a command in my mind.

Inventory Open, Summon!

At once, a ring appeared on my finger.

I normally kept the Myriad-Poison Ring in my Inventory to avoid attracting attention, but now it gleamed with a strange luster.

[2314] The hour of the Pig corresponds roughly to 9–11 p.m. in traditional East Asian timekeeping.

Ding.

SYSTEM

The usage conditions for the **Myriad-Poison Ring** have been met.
Special Skill **Poison Absorption** has activated!
Potent Paralysis Powder resists!

Hissss!

I could feel it. Deep inside my body, two energies with entirely different purposes collided.

But the Myriad-Poison Ring was a divine artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan, one that had even absorbed Jeok Cheongang's Formless Ultimate Poison.

And once my Scorching Yang Qi—the natural counter to poison—joined in, the paralysis powder had no choice but to collapse helplessly.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Detoxification complete!
All traces of **Potent Paralysis Powder** have disappeared from your body!
All Status conditions have been cleared!

"…Phew. You crazy old man."

I muttered the curse as I released the breath I had been holding.

He had set a trap like this the moment midnight passed. I never imagined that "we begin tomorrow" would mean this.

Damn it. He really is an assassin.

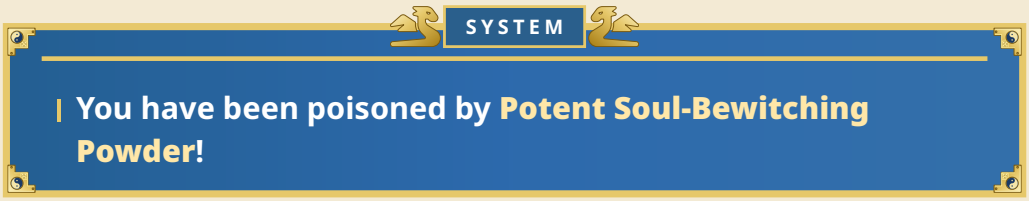
At first, I had thought it was an ambush by Dark Heaven.

Was this what he meant by turning me into a true Murim martial artist? I was already exhausted, and the sudden attack had sent my heart pounding and made my legs go weak. With a deep sigh, I collapsed onto the bed.

Phut-phut!

"…?"

Beep.



Slaughter Saint, you fucking bastard.

Chapter 491

“Hey, Captain. You haven’t slept—?”

Hyuk Mujin entered my temporary tent in the dim light before dawn, then fell silent as if he’d seen a ghost.

“Why?”

“Uh, well…”

“Say it.”

“It’s nothing. You just look unusually tired today.”

“…Hoo.”

Tired? Tired. Was that all I could call this?

I glared at the bronze basin of wash water. My hair was a mess, and my eyes were bloodshot. When I looked up, I saw that the entire tent was in shambles.

Hyuk Mujin belatedly noticed the same thing, and his pupils began quaking.

“What in the world happened here?”

“Yeah. Something happened.”

My voice sounded so unfamiliar it might have belonged to someone else. I rubbed my haggard face and muttered, “That fucking assassin…”

I’d said it quietly, but not quietly enough. Mujin jumped at the word *assassin*.

“Pardon? An assassin?”

“What?”

“You just said ‘assassin.‘ I heard you.”

“You heard wrong.”

“I heard it with my own ears.”

“I said you heard wrong.”

Of course, it was true.

Some vicious assassin bastard had installed a dozen or so hidden weapons inside the tent, and I had managed to trigger every single one of them. With a one-hundred-percent success rate, I had been reduced to a bloody rag.

The maddening part was that I couldn’t tell anyone.

“C-Captain…”

“I said you heard wrong!”

“That’s not it. You’re bleeding from your butt.”

“…!”

Fuck. No wonder my ass had felt warm.

As I cursed silently and pressed a hand to the wound, Mujin gave me a dubious look.

“I still think it was an assassin.”

"I got hurt training."

"Really?"

I nodded weakly.

This counted as training. I had no idea what kind of training involved staying awake all night doing nothing but detoxifying poison, but it counted.

"It really was training. I swear on both your balls."

"As I've told you repeatedly, please don't swear on my balls. And if an assassin is threatening you right now, blink twice."

"…Mujin. If you're going to ask me that, shouldn't you at least use Sound Transmission?"

"I can't use Sound Transmission yet."

"Then write it down."

"Oh. Right."

"Are you insane?"

Then again, this was Hyuk Mujin. What had I expected?

I let out a long sigh and looked him up and down. He'd dressed neatly in his martial robes and come to see me this early, so he clearly wanted something.

"Anyway, what's going on?"

"Ah, Sir Zhuge is looking for you. Everyone's gathered."

"Everyone? Why?"

"You know."

Mujin glanced around for no reason, then mouthed a few words before finally lowering his voice to a whisper meant only for me.

"The imugi[2315]. The dead one."

"Ah."

"Only a handful of us are going, and we're keeping it quiet. Perfected Being Hyeongong of Wudang is waiting too."

"Even Perfected Being Hyeongong? Ah, of course."

He was the only Supreme Peak master involved in this incident who had remained at Donghu Stronghold.

He was also the Wudang Sect Leader's Junior Brother and a respected elder of the Murim. He was more than qualified to attend as Wudang's representative.

However closely we guarded the Water God Dragon's existence, we couldn't keep it secret from Wudang.

Though for something this important, wouldn't the Sect Leader himself come? Why Hyeongong?

The question occurred to me, then vanished as I thought of someone else.

[2315] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often said to be capable of becoming a dragon.

“Hey, is anyone else going with us—”

I was about to finish the question, half hoping I was wrong, when a quiet voice came from outside the tent.

“Young Master Jin. Everyone is waiting.”

“…!”

“If you’re ready, please come out.”

The presence outside receded as soon as the words ended. Mujin tilted his head at the sight of me standing frozen.

“What’s wrong?”

“Why is *he* going?”

“Who? Oh, Mungyeong? He is the Divine Physician’s disciple, after all. He should be able to help with the imugi’s anatomy and such. But why?”

Why? Because I had no idea what that lunatic might do.

I swallowed the words rising in my throat and started toward the exit. Then I stopped and turned back to Mujin.

“Mujin.”

“Yes?”

“Go first. I’ll follow right behind you.”

“Pardon?”

I could almost hear a System notification ringing in my ears.

When I boarded the small vessel waiting for us, I found several familiar faces.

Perfected Being Hyeongong, dressed in a heavily patched Daoist robe with an old Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword at his waist, greeted me with a gentle smile.

“A young fellow Daoist has arrived. It is good to see you again.”

“Greetings, Perfected Being Hyeongong.”

I gave a fist-and-palm salute, now fairly convincing as a martial artist. Beside him, Zhuge Feng waved his folded fan and cut in.

“But your face…”

“Nothing happened.”

“You don’t look well for someone to whom nothing happened. Don’t you agree, Perfected Being?”

“I agree with Family Head Zhuge. You look as though an assassin tormented you all night.”

“An assassin? Perfected Being, you do make jokes. Ha ha.”

“Ho ho ho.”

“…”

Don’t laugh. Don’t even show me your teeth.

Without the Myriad-Poison Ring, I doubted I’d be standing right now.

I had been soaked in so much poison that I had seriously considered whether I should change my sobriquet from the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon to something like Poisoned Pickle.

Look at him, sitting there shamelessly.

I glared at Mungyeong, who had already claimed a seat on the swift ship.

The boy noticed my piercing gaze and slowly turned his head.

—Lower your eyes.

“…”

If he said lower them, I lowered them.

I quietly looked away, and another Sound Transmission followed.

—Judging by your condition, you must have fallen for every trap from the first day. How pathetic. If you hadn’t had the Myriad-Poison Ring and Scorching Yang Qi, you would have been dead by now.

—…How do you know whether I would have died or survived?

—Want me to tell you?

—I misspoke.

He wasn’t wrong. Every hidden weapon he’d set was coated with powerful poison.

I had once heard that medicine and poison shared the same source. I didn’t know who had said it, but they had been completely right. Somehow, every poison I suffered came with the adjective *potent* attached to it.

Only the Myriad-Poison Ring’s absurd effectiveness and my Scorching Yang Qi—a natural counter to poison—had kept me from suffering anything worse than a few puncture wounds.

Without those two things… Just thinking about it made my blood run cold.

Medical apprentice, my ass. What kind of Divine Physician is that? He’s a Poison Physician.

—I know you just insulted me.

“Ghk.”

I sucked in a startled breath before I could stop myself. Kindhearted Hyeongong looked at me with concern.

“What’s wrong, young friend?”

“Ah, nothing. It’s just a habit.”

“That’s a relief. For a moment, I thought an assassin really was threatening you. Didn’t you, Family Head Zhuge?”

“Ha ha ha! You’ll have me splitting my sides, Perfected Being!”

“Ho ho ho.”

“…”

I was tempted to tear Zhuge Feng’s navel right out.

While I glared at his stomach, the vessel slipped through the calm water. The departure was so smooth that I noticed it a beat too late.

“Wait. The Old Master—no, my Master isn’t here.”

Zhuge Feng looked puzzled by my sudden objection.

“Hm? Didn’t you hear?”

“Hear what?”

“Senior Jeok decided not to come. He also said not to look for him for the time being, until everything is finished.”

“…Is that so?”

“You didn’t know? That explains why he didn’t pass the message along through his Disciple.”

This was the first I’d heard of it.

Whatever his reason, it stung a little that he hadn’t said a word to me. At the same time, I thought I understood how he felt.

He must have a lot on his mind.

I’d never raised a Disciple, but if I found myself in his position someday, I thought I might feel the same way.

Perhaps it was like entrusting a beloved pet—one you’d cared for with love and devotion, almost like family—to someone else.

“…”

No, scratch that. That made me Jeok Cheongang’s pet dog.

His son. Right, let’s go with son.

While I was settling that with myself, Cheongpung came over with a bright smile and thrust something toward me.

“What’s this?”

“Candy, Benefactor.”

“…I can see that. Where do you keep finding it?”

There were only two possibilities.

Either Cheongpung was a System user with ten metric tons[2316] of candy in his Inventory, or there was a tree nearby that grew the stuff.

“Either way, thanks.”

[2316] Ten metric tons is 10,000 kg, or about 22,000 lb.

Normally I wouldn't have given it a second glance, but with so much on my mind, I could use the sugar. I bit into the candy and asked, "Finding candy at a time like this takes some skill. Did you buy it on your last visit to the Zhuge Clan?"

"No. I ate all of that already."

"Hm? Then where did this come from?"

"Slaugh—no, Mungyeong gave it to me. He told me to give this one specially to you, Benefactor. He's a really good person!"

"…Who?"

The answer came from somewhere else.

Beep.

SYSTEM

You have been poisoned by Potent Energy-Dispersing Poison!
Energy-Dispersing Poison temporarily prevents you from using internal energy.
Your internal energy is slowly dissipating! Immediate action is required!

"…"

Fuck. No wonder the candy had tasted unusually sweet.

I quietly took out the Myriad-Poison Ring.

They say people leave their names behind when they die, while beasts leave their hides.

The same was true of the spirit creature that had ruled Dongting Lake and the Yangtze for five hundred years.

The Water God Dragon's spirit had already left its body, but the body remained where it had last lain, retaining all the majesty and beauty it had possessed in life.

"…Hoo."

Even Perfected Being Hyeongong, an old Daoist of profound insight and enlightenment, was lost for words. All he could manage was a single exclamation.

The sight of the Water God Dragon's body was that overwhelming.

Even Gung Gibang, who had seen it before, stood with his mouth hanging open and kept exclaiming in awe.

"It's incredible even the second time around. Don't you think?"

I answered as politely as I could.

"It is. So is your breath. Could you get lost? I think it's stronger than the Energy-Dispersing Poison."

"Hm. Easily done. On one condition."

"What?"

"Of the ten silver nyang[2317] you promised me yesterday, I still haven't received five. I knew you were shameless, but I never thought you'd go so far as to prey on a beggar."

"I'll pay you. Just keep it short. I'm starting to see things."

I could hardly tell whether that was his mouth or a sewer.

Gung Gibang finally got the other five silver nyang[2318] out of me, then grumbled.

"Stop exaggerating. And if you mean hallucinations, I've had more than enough of those myself. I've been having strange dreams for the past few days."

"Dreams?"

"Yes. Dreams."

Gung Gibang gave a quiet laugh and pointed at Mungyeong.

"I dreamed Mungyeong was fighting that imugi. Sword Force was flying everywhere, and he kept vanishing and reappearing like a ghost… If someone had told me he was the Slaughter Saint, the greatest assassin of all time, I'd have believed them."

"…"

He is the Slaughter Saint.

I continued staring at the Water God Dragon's body, doing my best to ignore Gung Gibang's endless chatter.

From head to tail, its enormous body stretched for more than a hundred ja[2319]. Its scales, once stained black, now scattered dazzling silver light, while countless wounds were carved across its body.

I ran my hand over one of the gaping wounds and apologized silently.

I'm sorry.

Of course I knew the battle had been unavoidable. I had no reason to apologize. If anything, the Water God Dragon had been grateful to us for stopping it, even if this was what it had taken.

But I was apologizing because I couldn't bury its body as it was.

The corpse.

The raid was over. It was time to dispose of the corpse.

[2317] A silver *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency.

[2318] A silver *nyang* is a traditional unit of silver currency.

[2319] *Ja* is a Korean unit of length equal to about 30.3 cm (11.9 in). A hundred ja is about 30 m (99 ft).

Chapter 492

It went without saying that so many people had gathered here for reasons other than praying for the Water God Dragon's soul.

And one person in particular was showing rather obvious ulterior motives.

"Incredible. Simply incredible."

Zhuge Feng's eyes shone with rapture as he stroked the silver scales.

"This strength. This beauty. I can hardly believe it."

The Water God Dragon had died without ever becoming a true dragon, but it was still a divine imugi[2320] that had lived for five hundred years.

Its body had already proven itself in battle. It was both armor and a weapon in its own right.

"This is… a priceless treasure."

Zhuge Feng wasn't exaggerating in the slightest.

The scales were harder than steel, and even Sword Energy could not cut clean through them. The bones beneath were harder still.

Even in the modern age, with its advanced Magic-powered forging, material like this would sell for whatever price its owner named. In Murim, its value went without saying.

It may not be on the level of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, but… it's an incredible treasure.

The Water God Dragon's body stretched for more than a hundred zhang,[2321] and every inch of it was made up of treasures like those.

Armor made from those scales would not be pierced even by a crossbow. A weapon made from its bones would be harder and sharper than one made from meteorite iron.

Martial arts manuals, elixirs, and exceptional weapons—the three things every martial artist went crazy for.

It was only natural that greed showed in Zhuge Feng's eyes, and in several others'.

"If we made a Dog-Beating Staff[2322] out of that…"

Hyuk Mujin objected to Gung Gibang's muttering.

"Why make a Dog-Beating Staff[2323] out of the bones? You'd want a sword. A Bone Sword made from an imugi's[2324] bones… Just imagine it."

"Are you looking down on the Beggars' Sect?"

[2320] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore that may become a dragon.

[2321] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese unit equal to ten *chi*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred zhang is about 303 m (994 ft).

[2322] The Dog-Beating Staff is the signature weapon associated with the Beggars' Sect.

[2323] The Dog-Beating Staff is the signature weapon associated with the Beggars' Sect.

[2324] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore that may become a dragon.

"No. Just you, Gung Gibang."

"Want me to beat you like a dog?"

"Come on, calm down. There's enough there to make a hundred Dog-Beating Staffs[2325] or swords with plenty left over. Why fight about it?"

"Fair point. Then I call one Dog-Beating Staff.[2326]"

"And I'll reserve a sword…"

Crack! Crack!

"Ugh!"

"Argh!"

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin each took a smack to the back of the head. They turned to me and shouted.

"Why'd you hit me?"

"Please tell us why *before* you hit us!"

These bastards still didn't get it.

I frowned and shook a large fist at them threateningly.

"You two useless bastards couldn't do a damn thing when we were fighting, and now you're talking about Dog-Beating Staffs?[2327] Swords? Reservations?"

"Well, that's…"

"A martial artist can't help…"

"If it weren't for the Water God Dragon, Hubei Province would've been destroyed. It wouldn't have ended with a few fish going berserk."

There was no denying that countless people had died because of the Water God Dragon.

But it hadn't acted of its own free will. And if the Gate had opened completely, Hubei Province would have become a hellscape.

"Of course its body will be put to good use. But if you're even remotely human, show some gratitude. Got it?"

The two of them flinched at my shout and muttered in voices as tiny as ants.

"Like you do…"

"Honestly, Captain, you don't have much room to talk. Look what you did to the Dongting Fisherman."

Crack! Crack-crack!

Two more cries followed the blows. I rounded on Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin as they clutched their heads again.

"Is that the same thing? Is it? Huh?"

I had my side of that story too.

[2325] The Dog-Beating Staff is the signature weapon associated with the Beggars' Sect.

[2326] The Dog-Beating Staff is the signature weapon associated with the Beggars' Sect.

[2327] The Dog-Beating Staff is the signature weapon associated with the Beggars' Sect.

Of course I felt bad about wrecking the Dongting Fisherman, but I'd had no choice.

He'd been directly exposed to the corrupted Water God Dragon's Fear. He'd harmed people while out of his mind, and every piece of evidence at the time had pointed to him as the culprit.

His limbs might have been broken, but at least he was alive. Come to think of it, getting beaten to a pulp by me had freed him from the Fear.

A fist beat Fear.

A triumph of humanity…

No, not really. We'd each had our circumstances.

I'd even visited him because I felt bad. He was unconscious, though, so we hadn't been able to talk.

"Anyway, be grateful. Understand?"

I was still shaking my fist at the two of them when another voice spoke.

"Young Friend Jin is right."

There was wisdom in the voice alone. Perfected Being Hyeongong of Wudang stepped forward, his expression troubled.

"I had my doubts when I heard what happened, but seeing it with my own eyes, I understand now. It truly is a divine creature blessed by the heavens."

Jin Wikyung, who was also seeing the Water God Dragon for the first time, nodded solemnly.

"You're quite right, Perfected Being. It sacrificed itself to prevent even greater bloodshed. This imugi[2328] deserves to be called a Divine Dragon."

"A terrible loss. We owe it so much. Should we not all pray for its soul together?"

Perfected Being Hyeongong was exactly what one would expect from an old Daoist who had cultivated profound Daoist mastery at Wudang, the sacred ground of Daoism.

He was nothing like the human garbage beside me, who couldn't muster a shred of gratitude.

Overcome by a sudden surge of faith in the Primordial Heavenly Venerable,[2329] I quickly clasped my hands together.

"Amen."

Hyeongong, who had been reciting a Daoist prayer, flinched and turned to me.

"Amen?"

"My mistake. Amitabha.[2330]"

"…Repeat after me. Infinite Life Buddha.[2331]"

[2328] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore that may become a dragon.

[2329] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is a deity in Daoism.

[2330] Amitabha is a Buddha whose name is used as a Buddhist invocation.

[2331] Infinite Life Buddha is a Buddhist invocation referring to the Buddha of Infinite Life.

"Ah, sorry. Infinite Life Buddha.[2332]"

"Excellent. The Primordial Heavenly Venerable[2333] will watch over you, Young Friend Jin."

"Ah. Yes."

Does Wudang have missionaries too?

Hyeongong smiled like a Civilization[2334] player going for a religious victory. After a short prayer, he looked up at the sky.

"You, divine imugi.[2335] I pray that you become an Azure Dragon there and soar across the heavens."

"Ah…"

"Just as one would expect of you, Perfected Being."

Zhuge Feng and Jin Wikyung, each with his own interests at stake, eagerly sang his praises. Hyeongong answered with a kindly smile.

"Ho ho. I merely did what was right. Now then…"

"Yes, Perfected Being?"

What profound words would the old Daoist say next?

Everyone, myself included, bowed their heads and listened reverently.

"Let's start cutting it up."

"…?"

"We still have to do what needs to be done, do we not?"

"…!"

I raised my head.

Greed for a weapon blazed in Hyeongong's eyes. His gaze practically shouted what his voice did not.

I call a Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword! One Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword for me!

He wasn't a Daoist. He was a lunatic.

Looking at the man I'd trusted for all of a moment, I was reminded of something.

Every last one of these Murim bastards is hopeless.

The raid was over. The fighting wasn't.

One battle remained, and sometimes it got even fiercer than the raid itself.

Distribution of the spoils. Final settlement.

Hunters had to make a living, after all.

[2332] Infinite Life Buddha is a Buddhist invocation referring to the Buddha of Infinite Life.

[2333] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is a deity in Daoism.

[2334] *Civilization* is a strategy video game series in which a player can pursue a religious victory.

[2335] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore that may become a dragon.

Maybe things were different for top Hunters earning several billion to tens of billions of won[2336] a year. In a raid party of lower-tier Hunters, though, arguments over byproducts worth a few tens of thousands of won[2337] were commonplace. That was why contracts were essential.

And the Water God Dragon's corpse was a treasure of immense value all by itself.

We'd gone into this raid without drawing up a contract. In the modern world, that would have led to an enormous dispute.

But this was Murim. The people here belonged to the physical school: they preferred settling matters with their bodies to talking things out.

I knew just the word for people like that.

Suckers.

I glanced around. Nearly everyone was watching everyone else, waiting to see who would speak first.

Two people were exceptions.

The first was the Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, arguably the wealthiest family in Hubei.

"Ahem."

Zhuge Feng cleared his throat, then went on as though his proposal were perfectly reasonable.

"Our family will have to make a concession in this matter. The Zhuge Clan will take only ten percent. The rest can go to everyone else…"

"Hold it. Are you dealing from the bottom?[2338]"

"What!"

I cut him off with a quiet laugh.

"Ten percent? What did you do to earn ten percent? Take that much without working for it and you'll get a stomachache."

"You…"

"Am I wrong? I respect you, Sir Zhuge, but this isn't right."

Ten percent, when he didn't do a damn thing? How dare he try to sneak in and rob us blind?

Zhuge Feng flinched at my glare, then tried again.

"Barely did a thing? Without the information the Zhuge Clan provided, you would have been blind even with your eyes open. You never would have made it here."

"You have quite a long tongue."

"Ghk!"

[2336] Several billion to tens of billions of won is roughly ₩2 billion–₩99 billion, or about $1.4 million–$71 million and €1.3 million–€64 million.

[2337] A few tens of thousands of won is roughly ₩20,000–₩90,000, or about $14–$64 and €13–€58.

[2338] A famous line from the 2006 Korean gambling film *Tazza: The High Rollers*, used when catching a card cheat slipping cards from the bottom of the deck. Here it accuses the Zhuge Clan of rigging the split.

“The conclusion you reached from that information was that the Dongting Fisherman was the culprit. Wasn’t it? You’re telling me that the Dongting Fisherman, lying there injured, suddenly got up, did five somersaults, and then used Stepping on Empty Air to hop all the way here?”

“That… that was…”

Zhuge Feng fell silent. The only other person there who looked at ease gave him a gentle smile.

It was the smile of a man whose skill had brought the Jin Family of Taiyuan to its current standing.

“Sir Zhuge, I apologize for my younger brother’s rudeness.”

“C-Cough!”

“It’s my fault for teaching him so poorly.”

“His words were rather harsh.”

“They must have hurt your feelings. I really shouldn’t have let this happen.”

“It’s all right. At least you seem reasonable, Lesser Family Head, so I’m glad…”

“No. He deserves a proper scolding. Taekyung, you little rascal! Apologize at once!”

At Jin Wikyung’s booming shout, I immediately bowed my head.

“I’m sorry. I spoke too harshly.”

“Even if Sir Zhuge was trying to get something for nothing, there are lines you must not cross!”

“I apologize again.”

“No, wait. Hold on. Lesser Family Head Jin?”

Zhuge Feng seemed to sense something was wrong, but Jin Wikyung’s scolding went on.

“Taekyung, you played the greatest part in defeating the Water God Dragon! You practically saved Sir Zhuge’s life! But he is still the Family Head of a great clan and a respected elder of Murim!”

“Whew. I’ve committed a crime worthy of death.”

“Wait, Lesser Family Head.”

“You may have been raised without manners, but you’re still a youngster! How dare you treat Sir Zhuge, a man renowned throughout Murim, as though he were some shameless bastard? As soon as we return to our family, I’ll…!”

“Lesser Family Head Jiiin!”

Zhuge Feng cried out desperately and waved a hand, looking thoroughly fed up.

“All right. I understand. I understand everything. Just see that I’m taken care of.”

“Then you accept our apology?”

“I’m sorry, Sir Zhuge!”

“Yes, yes, I understand. Now both of you, stop.”

“Thank you. Even if it isn’t ten percent, we’ll make sure the Zhuge Clan gets a share it can be happy with.”

“A consolation cut is the universal rule.”

“…Whew.”

Game over. Yoshi, grand season.[2339]

Zhuge Feng wilted, worn out in body and spirit. Jin Wikyung and I exchanged satisfied smiles.

I could die and come back to life and still never match Zhuge Feng’s intellect. But you couldn’t learn this kind of negotiation at a desk.

This was wisdom born of experience.

I’d thrown a fit during a settlement to get one extra goblin poison dart. Jin Wikyung had spent years mastering the divine art of handling every shitty job the family could dump on him while no one knew whether his father was alive or dead.

If everyone else here was a sucker, we were cardsharps.

And judging by our contributions, I was obviously the star of the show.

Those who fight claim the spoils.

This was a battle we couldn’t retreat from—and shouldn’t.

Only by standing our ground against anyone who challenged us could we become true Hunters and true martial artists.

“Ten percent. Hand it over. Or hand over your neck.”

“We’ll hand it over.”

But there were exceptions to every rule.

…Fuck.

[2339] “Yoshi, grand season” is a Korean internet catchphrase used to celebrate a win.

Chapter 493

Opportunity isn't given to everyone equally.

By that measure, Perfected Being Hyeongong had been given more opportunities than most. At just ten years old, he had become a direct Disciple of the Wudang Sect Leader.

His path had been smooth from the start.

Born with martial talent among the best of his generation and an upright nature to match, Hyeongong had always received wholehearted support. Which meant he had never wanted for anything in his life.

And yet…

I want it.

Perfected Being Hyeongong's eyes trembled faintly. It was a material desire he had not felt in a very long time.

I've never felt this way before.

Gold, wealth, fame, glory—he had no need for any of it. He wore each Daoist robe he received until it fell apart and lived on simple, modest meals.

Elixirs and martial arts manuals were no different. Since reaching the Supreme Peak realm, he had devoted himself to cultivating his mind. Whenever his Senior Brother, the Sect Leader, offered him an elixir, Hyeongong passed it on to his promising grand-disciples. As for manuals, the Wudang techniques he had already mastered were more than enough.

But this. This was different.

"Hoo… Infinite Life Buddha.[2340] Infinite Life Buddha."

Hyeongong ran a rough hand down his beard and recited the invocation. Yet despite his efforts to master himself, his gaze kept returning to the imugi's[2341] corpse.

They say those bones are incredibly hard.

Through the split scales and gaping wound, he could see enormous bones giving off a faint glow. Perhaps because they had belonged to a five-hundred-year-old imugi, the bones had a luster unlike anything else. He had heard they were so hard that even ordinary Sword Energy could not cut through them.

If I made a sword from those bones, it would be incredible… No. What am I thinking? Get a grip, Hyeongong!

He squeezed his eyes shut. He had just watched the two Jin brothers leave Zhuge Feng in tatters, which made the temptation all the more troubling.

[2340] "Infinite Life Buddha" is an invocation of Amitabha, the Buddha associated with infinite life.

[2341] An *imugi* is a legendary serpent-like creature associated with dragons in Korean folklore.

At least Zhuge Feng had been there when the battle took place. Hyeongong had been hundreds of li[2342] away, at the Donghu Stronghold headquarters. He had no grounds to demand anything, nor the nerve to set aside his shame and ask.

Infinite Life Buddha, Infinite Life Buddha. A Daoist, led astray by a desire like this? Get a hold of yourself, Hyeongong.

While he was struggling in silence, someone spoke.

"Perfected Being. Are you busy?"

"Hm?"

Hyeongong's eyes flew open. A familiar young man was looking at him with a knowing gaze.

Jin Taekyung.

Together with the Sword Saint's Disciple, Cheongpung—the Huashan Divine Dragon—this young man was at the center of the storm sweeping through Murim. The gossips were already saying that beneath the Ten Kings stood the Two Dragons.

An extraordinary young man. Almost unbelievably so.

But Hyeongong had something more pressing on his mind than his opinion of Jin Taekyung.

Could it be?

The old Daoist looked at him, his heart quickening with hope.

"What is it, Young Friend Jin?"

Taekyung smiled gently. "If you're not busy, I was hoping we could talk."

"Talk? About what?"

"We have to deal with the corpse now, and there's more of it than we expected."

"Th-That's why?"

"You came all the way here in person. Of course you should have something to take home."

"Oh!"

Hyeongong's eyes immediately lit up. Jin Taekyung smiled and continued.

"Our Jin Family of Taiyuan has always held the Daoists of Wudang in the highest regard. As fellow martial artists of Murim, we'd be delighted to share a little of what we've gained."

"I-Is that true?"

"Of course. I swear on Hyuk Mujin's balls. My eldest brother is fully in favor of it too."

"Good heavens! Infinite Life Buddha!"

[2342] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

Taekyung had gently scratched the itch Hyeongong had been too ashamed to mention. The old Daoist was beside himself with joy.

Hyeongong did not know who Hyuk Mujin was or why Jin Taekyung was swearing on the man's balls. All that mattered was that he was being given a share.

How can anyone be this kind?

Taekyung was nothing like the hypocrites with their fine words. He was a ray of light shining into a cold Murim crawling with shameless people.

Hyeongong could practically see a halo over Jin Taekyung's head.

"Thank you! May the Primordial Heavenly Venerable[2343] protect you and the Jin Family of Taiyuan, young friend! Infinite Life Buddha!"

"Amen."

Something about that was strange, but Hyeongong didn't care. He was still beaming when Taekyung continued in his gentle voice.

"There is one small problem, though."

"Hm? What problem?"

"The corpse is so large that I can't deal with it alone. And we can't exactly move it whole."

"Quite right. Quite right."

From head to tail, its vast body stretched over a hundred jang.[2344] It was questionable whether it could even be moved in one piece. And since doing so would require a great deal of manpower, keeping the matter secret would become even more impossible.

"So I'd like to ask you a small favor, Perfected Being."

Hyeongong faltered. Suspicion flickered in his eyes.

"Wait. Young Friend Jin. This favor of yours wouldn't happen to mean…"

"Yes. We need you to lend us a hand. At this rate, it'll take days."

So that's it! That's why he was being so generous!

Hyeongong glared at Jin Taekyung with an expression of betrayal.

"You want me to use Wudang's sword arts to take that imugi's corpse apart?"

"Think of it as work."

"Work? You expect me to think of it as work? I did not train in martial arts for this!"

Reaching the Supreme Peak realm meant devoting most of one's life—no, one's entire life—to martial arts.

Hyeongong was no exception. How many years had he spent with a sword as his companion, his beloved? He had even honed his martial arts through secluded

[2343] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is a deity in Daoism.

[2344] A *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred jang is about 303 m (994 ft).

meditation, facing a wall in pitch darkness. To him, Taekyung's request was an insult.

The nerve of him.

His expression hardened.

"Infinite Life Buddha. Young friend, you have insulted not only me but the sword arts of the great Wudang Sect."

"Insulted you? I would never. I'm only asking you to lend a hand."

"But I cannot use my sword for something as trivial as—"

Just as Hyeongong's voice began to rise, Taekyung tossed out a remark.

"Now that I look at it, your sword's pretty worn."

"What?"

"Seems about time you replaced it. What do you think?"

"…!"

Hyeongong's pupils quivered. Before he knew it, he was looking down at the old Pine-Pattern Ancient Sword at his waist.

It certainly is worn… No! What am I thinking?

He had carried that sword since he was ten. It was a precious gift from his late master.

Hyeongong hurriedly shook his head to clear it, then opened his eyes wide.

"It is not worn!"

"It is. Look at the hilt. It's practically falling apart."

"It does seem a little… No! You're mistaken!"

"Fine, forget the hilt. The scabbard's covered in cracks too. Has it been through a drought?"

"Ah! When did those appear…?"

"This is worse than I thought. Could you draw the sword?"

"Why should I?"

Shing!

Only after shouting did Hyeongong realize he had drawn it. He stared in horror.

When did I do that?

The devil's whisper went on regardless.

"The blade doesn't look too good either."

"My late master gave me this sword!"

Taekyung answered calmly. "My parents gave me this body, but it's worn down with use. If I could've replaced it, I would have done it ages ago."

"Well, this old Daoist's joints have been aching lately too. I've been yearning for Bone Transformation[2345]… What are you trying to pull?"

[2345] Bone Transformation is a transformative stage of physical renewal in martial-arts fiction.

"I'm just telling you the cold reality. Oh, the edge is still sharp, at least."

Get a grip. Get a grip, Hyeongong.

He steadied his breathing and answered with pride. "Of course it is. The blade was forged with four nyang[2346] of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron mixed into it."

"Good heavens. Four nyang of that precious Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron?"

"Do you see now? This sword may look worn, but it is every bit a treasured sword."

"Ah. Is that right?"

"Of course! I already own a sword anyone would covet. Why would I need another —"

Clang!

"Oh, sorry. My hand slipped and I dropped my spear. Please, go on."

Hyeongong barely noticed Taekyung's sheepish smile. His eyes were fixed on the faintly glowing spear, his eyelids trembling.

"Y-Young Friend Jin. Is that, by any chance…"

"Nothing special. It's made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron too, but it's nothing compared to your sword."

It certainly didn't look that way.

Hyeongong swallowed and asked cautiously, "How many nyang?"

"Solid. The whole thing, from the blade to the shaft."

"This is fucking insane. Infinite Life Buddha."

"Sorry? What was that?"

"Ah, nothing. Nothing at all."

A devil. This was the devil's whisper.

Yet Hyeongong's eyes remained fixed on Jin Taekyung's spear, White Flame, as he recited the invocation as if possessed.

"Light as a feather, incredibly hard, and sharp besides. But…"

Then that soft, tempting voice reached his ears again.

"I think I'd like a weapon made from an imugi's bones."

"Infinite Life Buddha. I would not."

"Think about it carefully. Not just any weapon, but one containing all the qi of a sacred imugi that lived for no less than five hundred years."

It would be incredible. I want one so badly.

Hyeongong barely swallowed the words rising to his lips and shook his head frantically.

"Impossible! I could never abandon the sword my master gave me—"

[2346] A *nyang* is a traditional weight unit of approximately 37.5 g (1.32 oz); four nyang is about 150 g (5.29 oz).

“Who said anything about abandoning it? You can have both.”

“Fuck, I could do that! Ah, Primordial Heavenly Venerable!”

“Sorry?”

“Stop! That’s enough! Infinite Life Buddhaa!”

“If you help us, we’ll give you a share generous enough that Wudang won’t feel slighted. Do you think I’d settle this with a single sword?”

“I already have a sword made with Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron!”

“Yes. And an imugi’s bones.”

“How could I use another sword when I have the one my master gave me?”

“Yes. The more, the better.”

“I did not learn martial arts for this sort of thing!”

As Hyeongong clung to his last shred of pride and lamented, Jin Taekyung suddenly shouted toward somewhere behind the corpse.

“Hey, Cheongpung! How’s it going?”

A cheerful face popped out from behind the enormous corpse. Cheongpung had been promised a considerable share for fighting alongside them.

“Yes, Benefactor! I’m working on the waist!”

“Really? That part’s especially thick. Giving you trouble?”

“No! The Martial Extremity Grand Unity Sword cuts through it just fine!”

“Good. I’ll be there soon. Keep at it.”

“Yes, Benefactor!”

Taekyung gave the diligent worker a pleased smile, then turned back to Hyeongong.

“Ah, sorry, Perfected Being. I took my eyes off the work for a moment.”

“…”

“But what were we talking about? I’ve been forgetting things a lot lately.”

Hyeongong looked from Cheongpung, hard at work, to Taekyung and back again.

Half a shichen[2347] later…

Slash!

The Taiji Wisdom Sword, Wudang’s finest sword technique, was separating the imugi’s scales from its bones.

“Murim has gone completely mad.”

That was Mungyeong’s brief assessment as he watched the entire situation unfold.

[2347] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Chapter 494

Slash! Shhk-shhk-shhk!

Scales split apart, and huge chunks of flesh were cut into evenly sized pieces.

The enormous bones emerging between them were so clean it hardly seemed possible.

Thud! Slash!

His skill bordered on the supernatural.

As the onlookers stared in a daze, a quiet murmur spread through the crowd.

“Hyuk. I’m asking because I genuinely don’t know, but… Was the Jin Family of Taiyuan originally a family of fishermen?”

“Can I ask the Lesser Family Head that exact question?”

“Of course not, you lunatic. But you’d have to be born with a talent like that. Could he actually be a fisherman…?”

“Lesser Family Head! Do you know what Gung Gibang just said?”

“Hey, hey!”

“Was one of our ancestors a fisherman? How can the youngest one do that?”

“…Lesser Family Head?”

“If Zhuge Wuhou[2348] had seen this, he’d have fallen right out of his four-wheeled carriage. Wouldn’t you agree, Perfected Being Hyeongong?”

“Good heavens. Infinite Amen, Avalokiteshvara.[2349]”

“…Perfected Being?”

While everyone questioned the roots of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and worked toward religious unification, one person was thinking about something else entirely.

Huh. Look at this guy.

Mungyeong’s clear eyes followed Jin Taekyung as he cut and sliced like a man possessed.

What incredible power. And it’s fast and concise, too.

You could tell a person’s realm from the smallest movement. By that measure, what Jin Taekyung was doing was astonishing.

What an achievement. Hard to believe he’s barely past twenty.

Mungyeong already knew Jin Taekyung defied common sense. Everyone in this dusty martial world knew it. Even the young prodigies of the Nine Sects and One Gang, with all the support they received, struggled to break through to Peak at

[2348] Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific title for Zhuge Liang, the strategist of China’s Three Kingdoms period, often depicted riding in a wheeled carriage.

[2349] Avalokiteshvara is a bodhisattva associated with compassion in Buddhism. “Infinite Amen” jumbles the Buddhist invocation “Infinite Life Buddha” together with the Christian “Amen.”

twenty. Jin Taekyung had reached Supreme Peak and now stood shoulder to shoulder with masters one or even two generations above him.

But that was not the only reason Mungyeong admired him.

He moves like a veteran of the martial world. That control over his strength, at his age… Not a motion wasted.

Thump! Slash!

Even the smallest movement was efficient. He might have been conscious of all the people watching, but he showed none of the flashy affectation someone his age might have indulged in.

He simply cut, sliced, and separated, like a traveler quietly following the quickest, easiest path.

He was the same when he fought the imugi.[2350]

An assassin took in and analyzed everything around him. His profession demanded that he kill his target and find a way out, whatever the circumstances.

And Mungyeong was the Slaughter Saint, called the greatest assassin of all time.

He had watched Jin Taekyung ever since Sichuan—not as the Divine Physician, but through the eyes of the Slaughter Saint.

The Heavenly Martial Physique… Could it really be true?

It had been forty years since Mungyeong left Murim. For all that time—long enough for the mountains and rivers to change four times—he had lived as a medical apprentice. He had examined and treated thousands, perhaps tens of thousands, of patients.

Yet even with all that experience, he could not easily explain Jin Taekyung's body or talent.

He's similar to Cheongpung, but there's a subtle difference.

Mungyeong glanced at Cheongpung, then looked away.

Cheongpung was the only person who could be compared to Jin Taekyung. In his understanding and application of martial arts, he might even surpass him.

Cheongpung, too, had a remarkable body unlike any Mungyeong had seen. But not quite like Jin Taekyung's.

Cheongpung was refined. Jin Taekyung was born this way.

The shape and size of his muscles, his skeleton, his acupoints—everything was perfect.

The Heavenly Martial Physique.

Mungyeong's gaze deepened as he watched Jin Taekyung.

What if that boy made my secret martial arts entirely his own…?

He pushed the thought aside almost as soon as it came.

Ridiculous.

[2350] An imugi is a legendary Korean serpent-like creature often associated with dragons.

Martial arts were like an endless mountain range. Most martial artists still at its foot might think Mungyeong had reached the summit, but he could see another mountain ahead.

That was how vast and distant the world of martial arts was.

Even Mungyeong had not reached the end of the secret martial arts he practiced. Heavenly Martial Physique or not, Jin Taekyung could hardly achieve anything satisfactory with them in such a short time.

Especially now.

War was almost upon them. With countless battles ahead, Mungyeong needed to teach him what mattered most. Too much of anything could become poison.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, must have known that when he entrusted Jin Taekyung to him.

But… what on earth should I teach that bastard?

At a loss for the first time in a long while, Mungyeong watched the scene before him.

“Cheongpung! Ready?”

“Yes, Benefactor!”

“Lay into it with the Plum Blossom Sword Technique!”

“Agh!”

“Perfected Being! Where are you?”

“Oh. Here I am!”

“Why are you standing over there instead of working? Can’t you see the rest of us working?”

“I-I was just going to take a short break…”

“Perfected Being, you’re such an individualist! Where’s your teamwork?”

“I-I’m sorry.”

“Show me how sorry you are. Taiji Wisdom Sword, go!”

“I-Infinite Life Buddha![2351]”

Slash! Slash! Slash!

Under Jin Taekyung’s forceful direction, the Water God Dragon’s corpse was dismantled in no time.

The others cried out in admiration. Mungyeong only grew more troubled.

What am I supposed to teach that bastard?

At this point, he looked like the kind of person who would grow just fine on his own…

Then Mungyeong made up his mind.

[2351] Infinite Life Buddha refers to Amitabha, a Buddha whose name is invoked in Buddhist practice.

No. Now that he had taken this on, he would see it through to the end. He wanted to stay close and find out just how far that arrogant bastard Jin Taekyung could go.

First, I need to fix that absurdly complacent attitude of his.

Mungyeong slipped up beside Hyuk Mujin, who was staring with his mouth open.

“Martial Warrior Hyuk.”

“Holy shit. He cut through that in one go—oh, Mungyeong. What is it?”

“Young Master Jin must be exhausted. Would you take him some water?”

“Huh. You really do think of things the rest of us don’t. I’ll take it right over.”

“Please don’t tell him I gave it to you. I’d be happier if you got the praise.”

“You really are something…!”

Hyuk Mujin looked at Mungyeong with deeply moved eyes and accepted the leather waterskin.

Of course, along with cool water, it contained a deadly poison called Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder—an extreme poison that killed its victim before they could take seven steps.

“…What’s this?”

Immediately after the work was finished, Hyuk Mujin approached me with a leather waterskin. He answered my question with a proud expression.

“Water. I thought you might be tired, Captain.”

“There’s no way you thought of something this considerate.”

“I fetched it myself! Why don’t you trust me?”

Had I been too sensitive lately? He looked so wronged that I felt a little guilty for doubting him.

Besides, after working that long, I really was thirsty.

“Hm. Really?”

“Forget it. If you’re going to be like this, don’t drink it! I’ll drink it myself!”

“Hey, hey. Fine. Leave it here and go. I’ll drink it.”

“I said forget it!”

“That’s enough. You’re starting to piss me off.”

“…Yes.”

Once Mujin was gone, I carefully pulled the stopper from the waterskin and sniffed it.

Mm. Smell.

Smells normal, at least.

I still wasn’t letting my guard down. Very carefully, I tilted the waterskin.

A drop of water trickled out slowly and plopped onto my tongue.

Just in case, I'll start with one drop…

Beep.

> **System** - You have been poisoned by **Potent Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder**! - **Potent Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder** is an extreme poison capable of killing dozens of bulls with a single drop! - Severe **Internal Injury** and organ damage are likely. Very, very urgent treatment is required!

"…Hyuk Mujin, you son of a bitch."

Fuck. That wasn't the kind of one drop I'd had in mind.

Inventory open. Summon!

I hurriedly put on the Myriad-Poison Ring and raised my Scorching Yang Qi to drive out the poison.

The next System notification told me the poison had been purged. But that wasn't the end.

Beep.

> **System** - Quick action—but the extreme poison has left aftereffects! - Your **Sinews and Meridians** have suffered slight damage! - Some stats have decreased due to the damage to your **Sinews and Meridians**! - **Strength** decreased by 5! - **Agility** decreased by 5! - Status abnormality: **Severe Stomachache**! - Status abnormalities will return to normal once you have fully recovered, but the lost stat points cannot be restored!

"What the hell?"

No, fuck. Had I really lost stat points?

Not one or two, either. A whole ten points between Strength and Agility had vanished.

Ten points is one level-up!

Damn it. I knew exactly who was behind this.

I'd gone through hell to raise those stats, and now they were gone. Hot fury surged up from deep in my gut.

Grrrggg.

…Was that fury, or feces?

And of all the shitty status abnormalities to get, I had to get this one. My vision went white with pain, and I hurried off.

"Young Friend Jin, where are you going?"

"Benefactor, where are you going?"

“Move, move. We’re done dismantling it, so all that’s left is sorting. I need to take care of something first…”

“Benefactor, are you going to poop?”

Don’t say it so loudly, you lunatic. What if Mungyeong hears you?

Pale-faced, I stumbled on. Only when I got close to a place out of sight did I start to feel relieved.

Whew. Thank goodness.

Shitting myself while standing would be humiliating enough. If Mungyeong saw me, I’d be in for it.

Fortunately, he wasn’t among the others, so he must have gone somewhere else…

Wait. Somewhere else?

The question crossed my mind just as my foot touched the ground.

Then I heard a faint sound.

Step. Tap.

A chill ran down my spine. I launched myself into the air on instinct.

Shhk-shhk-shhk-shhk!

Four blades whistled through the air.

Four daggers came from the front, back, left, and right. They pierced the edges of my clothes and skimmed my skin. If I hadn’t dodged, they would have lodged in my chest, back, and limbs.

What the hell…!

I righted my body and landed on the ground, then glared furiously at the rock wall more than ten zhang[2352] away.

“Can we take it down a notch? Huh?”

The rock wall shimmered like a heat haze. A figure emerged and answered in a dry voice.

“I told you clearly. I decide how you train.”

“You put me in this state and then hide over there? You could at least face me—”

“I wasn’t hiding. I was watching.”

“What difference does that make? You got caught.”

“I showed myself just enough for you to notice. If you couldn’t manage even that, you might as well bite down on a blade and die.”

“You…”

“You?”

Mungyeong. No—the Slaughter Saint.

The moment I met his deep, steady gaze, goose bumps rose on my skin and hot fury surged up again.

[2352] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.3 m (10.8 ft).

Grrrrrrrk. Frrt.

“…”

“…”

It wasn’t fury. It was feces.

Chapter 495

When you're a baby, it would be stranger if you *could* control your bladder.

At seven? You're still in kindergarten. These things happen. In elementary school, it would be a little embarrassing, but it wasn't unheard of in the lower grades.

But I was twenty-seven.

The media of the twenty-first century were falling over themselves to call me a new hero, while the martial artists of Murim called me the Fire King's heir and a rising star destined to change the face of Murim.

And yet…

Fuck.

I'd shit myself. At twenty-seven. Not peed myself—shit myself. In front of Mungyeong, no less.

Ah, ahh. Anastasia![2353]

"…Take your time cleaning up and come back."

After a long silence, Mungyeong left me with those words.

He seemed less concerned for me than he was about getting shit on his short sword. That damn old man.

Every time I thought about what had just happened, I wanted to log out and never return to Murim again. To hell with Dark Heaven and everything else.

Should I just leave Murim altogether?

I was sitting by the water, seriously considering it, when someone approached with a smile.

"Captain. What are you doing here all by your—"

The moment I recognized him, I swore at him with all my heart.

"Hyuk Mujin, you son of a bitch."

"Why are you swearing at me all of a sudden?"

"Stay out of my sight for a while. Please."

"Even if you're the Captain, that's going too far. You wouldn't spit in a smiling man's face, would you?"

"Khack—ptui!"

"Gah!"

Mujin barely dodged the glob of phlegm. He looked me over as though I'd lost my mind.

"What happened to make you act like this?"

"Nothing happened. So shut up and get out of my sight."

"That doesn't quite add up."

[2353] In Korean, *Anastasia* (*Anaseutasya*) sounds like *a, na ssasseo*, "ah, I crapped myself."

“Want me to put your arms and legs where they don’t belong?”

Because of the water that bastard had brought me, I’d lost both stat points and my dignity.

I was barely keeping my fist to myself because I knew Mungyeong was the real culprit.

Mujin, who had no idea what had happened, looked baffled.

“Good grief. Anyone would think I’d made you shit your pants.”

“…!”

“What was that reaction?”

“…Nothing. Why are you here?”

He gave me a suspicious look, then pointed toward the people in the distance.

“We’ve mostly finished sorting everything, but something’s odd.”

“Odd? What?”

“There are fewer imugi[2354] bones and scales than we expected. I think you’d better come see for yourself.”

“Really?”

“Yes. Perfected Being Hyeongong[2355] is furious that there’s so little for an imugi that size. He’s combing the area like he’s hunting for lice. He says if someone stole any, he’ll find the culprit on the Primordial Heavenly Venerable’s[2356] honor.”

“…”

What was he, Detective Kindaichi?[2357]

He must have completely lost his mind after helping with the Taiji Wisdom Sword just to obtain some bones, only to think someone had snatched them away.

The more I listened, the more absurd it seemed, so I asked Hyuk Mujin,

“How could anyone steal it? And it’s not like only a little went missing. It must be well over a thousand geun.[2358] How could anyone hide that without us noticing?”

“Exactly. Hardly anyone even knows about this place—”

Mujin broke off and turned to me.

“But how did you know?”

“Hm?”

“How much was missing. You said it must be over a thousand geun.[2359]”

“Just a rough guess. They’ve been making a racket over there for a while.”

I answered as calmly as I could, but I felt a sudden stab of guilt.

[2354] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent, often associated with dragons.

[2355] Perfected Being is a Daoist honorific for a spiritually accomplished practitioner.

[2356] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is a Daoist deity.

[2357] Kindaichi Hajime is the teenage detective of the Japanese manga *The Kindaichi Case Files*, famous for solving elaborate murder mysteries.

[2358] A Korean *geun* is about 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

[2359] A Korean *geun* is about 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

Because…

He’s sharp. I need to watch what I say.

The culprit Perfected Being Hyeongong had sworn to find was me.

Just thinking about the haul piled up in my Inventory made me feel full.

Come to think of it, I did take a lot.

It had been easier than lying in bed playing with my smartphone.

The Water God Dragon’s corpse was enormous, and I’d worked on more of it than anyone else, sweeping the choicest parts into my Inventory as I went.

The sharpest tailbone. The unusually hard scales around its neck. Even some flesh, just in case.

Pile up everything I’d smuggled away, and it would dwarf a decent-sized manor.

“…Why are you smiling so contentedly?”

“Me? What smile?”

“Just now. You looked incredibly shady.”

Apparently, my delight at pulling off the perfect crime was written all over my face. I straightened my expression.

“I wasn’t smiling.”

“…”

“Anyway, leave them to it. Go get ready.”

“Ready for what?”

“To head back. You want to live here forever?”

People we could trust would move the sorted remains of the Water God Dragon discreetly, a little at a time.

Most of them would go to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

That’ll be a huge help in the battles ahead.

I got to my feet. Mujin was already running off in the distance, almost before I’d finished speaking. Watching his back, I called out inwardly.

Inventory open. Summon.

Shhk.

At the command, the Water God Dragon’s bones, scales, and flesh appeared in my hands. I couldn’t help smiling.

Item appraisal.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Water God Dragon's Bones
Type: Material
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Only a Master Artisan can forge them.
Description: The bones of the Water God Dragon, an imugi[2360] that lived for countless years. They are exceptionally strong and contain an unknown, mystical qi. A craftsman who has reached the proper realm may be able to draw out their true power.

Although there were slight differences, the System's description of the scales was similar.

They, too, were Supreme Peak materials of exceptional strength with mystical qi inside them. As for the flesh, eating it regularly over time could increase internal energy and stat points.

This is like winning the lottery.

But the real jackpot was something else.

If the bones and scales were Lotto tickets and the flesh an annuity lottery, this was the American Powerball. The prize was on another scale entirely.

My heart pounding, I took *it* out of the Inventory.

Item appraisal.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Water God Dragon's Origin Essence
Type: None
Grade: None
Restriction: None
Description: The Origin Essence of the Water God Dragon, an imugi[2361] that lived for countless years. Though damaged by magical power, it is a kind of inner core extracted according to the Water God Dragon's will. It holds an immense quantity of exceptionally pure qi and is unlike any ordinary elixir. However, if you cannot withstand the qi within it... Further details omitted.

[2360] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent, often associated with dragons.
[2361] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent, often associated with dragons.

That's incredible.

I carefully stroked the **Water God Dragon's Origin Essence** in my hand.

That last line was ominous, but this was the greatest thing I'd gained from the trip to Hubei.

Unlike any ordinary elixir… Just how powerful is it?

Having been contaminated by magical power, it couldn't contain as much qi as the Water God Dragon had possessed at its peak. Even so, the amount had to be enormous.

The Water God Dragon had lived for over five hundred years. By simple calculation, that meant it had accumulated at least ten jiazi[2362] of qi.

From that perspective, the reduction in the Origin Essence's power was practically a blessing in disguise.

Pour too much water into a small vessel, and it overflows.

As the final line of the item description suggested, even I would burst like a balloon if I tried to take in that much qi all at once.

The question is when and where to use it.

Several faces came to mind. One old face in particular kept returning.

Old Master.

Jeok Cheongang hadn't come to mind simply because he was old.

Strangely enough, it was because of Mungyeong's poison.

After Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder had cost me ten precious stat points, and a severe stomachache had made me shit myself, a thought had struck me.

If Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder did this much… What condition must Old Master be in after being poisoned by the Formless Ultimate Poison?

Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder was undoubtedly an extreme poison, but it wasn't enough to threaten the life of a Supreme Peak master.

The Formless Ultimate Poison that had struck Jeok Cheongang in Henan was far more toxic. Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder couldn't compare.

Even the Luoyang Strange Physician, one of the most renowned physicians in the world, had no answer and had advised us to seek the Divine Physician. And because the poison had already spread so far, we'd needed the Myriad-Poison Ring as well.

Fortunately, the Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng let us finish treating him…

But had he really recovered without any significant aftereffects?

I stared at the **Water God Dragon's Origin Essence**, doubt and worry mingling in my mind.

Perhaps this was an item whose purpose had been decided from the very beginning.

[2362] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

"Little Brother!"

Inventory open. Store.

I hurriedly put the **Water God Dragon's Origin Essence** back into my inventory at Jin Wikyung's shout from behind me, then turned around with an awkward smile.

"Yes, I'm coming!"

Today had been a day of many satisfying gains.

Yet something weighed on my heart, and for some reason, my stomach felt as though it were twisting.

Grrrggg.

"…Sigh."

Oh. The status abnormality still hadn't worn off.

Humans were not the only creatures that settled near water. Animals did too.

Birds nested along the cliffs above the broad waters of Dongting Lake. Wild boars, foxes, wolves, and even tigers lived there as well.

If Dongting Lake below the cliffs was territory permitted to humans, then the cliffs above belonged to the animals.

It was a peaceful place untouched by human feet.

So the great tiger, king of that place, was displeased to find an uninvited guest had arrived.

- Grrrrrrr.

Irritation rumbled through its sharp teeth. Its nose flared ceaselessly, following the human scent that still lingered in the air.

Its keen sense of smell soon found the source.

- Grrr.

At the edge of a sheer cliff, the great tiger spotted the intruder and snorted.

It had wondered what sort of creature had the nerve to come here. The answer was smaller and shabbier than it had expected: an old human who hardly looked worth a single bite.

Ssshhk.

Its body, weighing several hundred geun,[2363] moved nimbly toward the old man. It was at that very moment.

"So there was a tiger."

- …!

The tiger stopped short in its silent approach.

The old man had risen on his short legs and was staring straight at it.

[2363] A Korean *geun* is about 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

“You’re old too, I see.”

• Grrr.

The tiger bared its teeth. The old man only gave a short laugh.

“Quiet now. Come here and keep this old man company.”

• Raaaargh!

“You striped mutt, you want to die? I said come here.”

The tiger flinched.

It couldn’t have said why, but every hair on its body stood on end. It approached the old man with uncertain steps.

When the wrinkled hand gently scratched its chin, it felt good despite itself.

• Prrrrr.

Watching the great tiger purr, the old man—Fire King Jeok Cheongang—murmured softly.

“Yes. I’ve already grown old.”

The sky above the cliff was clear. His heart was dark.

Chapter 496

"Hmm."

Hyuk Mujin carefully picked up his brush. The small booklet spread across the table was already packed with entries from the past several days.

X Month X Day. Weather was shitty, then cleared up.

I had a nightmare about a monster that looked like a dragon. It scared me so badly I wet myself in my sleep.

As soon as I woke up, I sneaked down to the stream to wash my undergarments and trousers. Gung Gibang was already there, washing shit out of his trousers.

What a filthy bastard. Even among beggars, you'd be hard-pressed to find a worse one.

I have no idea why our Captain insists on dragging around someone who shits his pants.

But why am I in the infirmary?

X Month X Day. Clear skies.

The nightmare was real.

According to Mungyeong, the monster was an imugi[2364]. Demonic qi had seeped into its very marrow and driven it to commit an atrocity that outraged heaven and humanity.

Fortunately, thanks to the Captain stepping in, I was barely affected by the demonic qi. I was told to keep a diary for the time being and use it to piece my memories back together.

Still, I couldn't believe all those ridiculous things I'd seen had actually happened.

While Mungyeong was explaining, a question occurred to me. I asked if what I'd seen in the dream—no, what I'd seen there, with him fighting—had been real too.

Mungyeong said no. Gung Gibang joined in asking him about it, but for some reason, I fell asleep right there. I must have been tired.

Then why is there a bruise on my forehead?

I don't know. I'm going back to sleep.

X Month X Day.

I went to deal with the corpse. The imugi's enormous size nearly made me piss myself once, and the Captain's butchering skills nearly did it a second time.

I asked him to make me a Bone Sword and got beaten until my skull rang.

I heard the imugi's corpse would be transported in secret after being divided into bones, scales, and flesh.

[2364] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.

Oh, and for some reason, a considerable amount of the sorted remains disappeared.

Perfected Being Hyeongong was furious and declared that he would find the culprit, but that's ridiculous. We're not talking about something the size of a fist. Who could steal that much?

We left the little commotion behind and boarded the boat back. Once aboard, I noticed a terrible smell of shit coming from somewhere.

I couldn't stand it any longer and brought it up. Before I could finish speaking, the Captain pointed at Gung Gibang.

He denied it vehemently, but I saw him washing his shit-stained trousers a few days ago. How could I believe him?

Mungyeong sat beside me with an odd expression the whole time.

He probably wanted to curse Gung Gibang out over the smell but held back to spare his dignity.

What a good kid. Every time I see him, he seems so innocent and easy to like.

X Month X Day.

It's been two days since we dealt with the imugi's corpse.

I don't know why, but Sir Jeok hasn't been around at all, and the Captain looks gaunter by the day.

I joked that he looked like someone being tormented by poison and ambushes day and night. He glared at me as if he wanted to kill me.

He only takes it out on me because I'm an easy target.

Just as I was thinking that, Gung Gibang said the same thing and got beaten too. I felt better.

X Month X Day.

This is my first entry in three days. I haven't written because there was nothing worth writing about.

First Sir Jeok, and now the Captain has become hard to find. Mungyeong keeps wandering off somewhere too.

What else is a martial artist like me supposed to do with his free time? Gung Gibang and I found a decent place to train.

His breath smells like a sewer, but when he keeps his mouth shut and trains, he's not so bad.

Cheongpung somehow found us. Every bit of advice he gave was useless.

Whenever I asked him about martial arts, I got one of two answers.

"It's really easy."

"Why can't you do it?"

You bastard. If it were that easy, would I still be First Rate?

Maybe he got frustrated, because he demonstrated it for me. I still couldn't understand a thing.

Every time we train, that water snake called something like Mimi sits beside us swallowing Blood Fish. Maybe that's why it seems to have grown so much. Its horns too.

No wonder the Blood Fish seemed to have vanished. They must have all gone down that thing's throat.

X Month X Day.

I've become fairly friendly with a few martial artists from the Zhuge Clan and Wudang, and they've told me some things.

Under the direct supervision of Sir Zhuge Feng, the Crouching Dragon Guest, the Zhuge Clan is testing a formation to seal the gap completely.

Apparently, if they can't seal it, strange creatures like the Blood Fish will keep appearing. I have no idea what bizarre method those Dark Heaven bastards used to make such a thing.

Meanwhile, Wudang is still hunting the Killing Ghost.

Even with the authorities helping them comb through Hubei Province, they haven't found him. The bastard must have made an art of running away.

X Month X Day.

It has been seven days and nights since I came here. The Captain's complexion was calm when I saw him again after so long.

Before, he'd been covered in wounds from whatever training he was doing alone, and his face was either pale or tinged blue. He seems to be better now.

His temper has grown sharper instead, and he walks like a ghost.

He gives off so little sign of his presence that he caught Gung Gibang and me bad-mouthing him and beat us within an inch of our lives.

Seriously, how did he hear us from that far away?

Come to think of it, Mungyeong looked pleased while I was getting beaten… I must have imagined it.

"Hmm."

That was where the diary of what Hyuk Mujin had seen and experienced over roughly ten days ended.

He gazed down at the booklet, lost in thought. Just as he was about to put brush to paper for a new entry, excited shouts came from outside.

"It—it worked!"

"Family Head! We did it!"

"Not you—I did it! As expected, I'm a genius! Zhuge Wuhou![2365]"

Slip! Splotch!

[2365] Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific for Zhuge Liang, the historical Chinese statesman and strategist.

His concentration broke. His hand slipped, and the brush went astray.

Hyuk Mujin's face contorted. So much for writing with the bearing of a great literary master.

"Which bastard was that?"

A familiar voice slipped into his ear as he raged.

"The bastard you're talking about sounds like Sir Zhuge Feng. Shall I pass along your words?"

"Go ahead. Then Young Hero Gung dies, and I die right after him."

Hyuk Mujin answered gruffly and put down his brush as Gung Gibang entered the tent without permission.

"But what on earth is happening outside?"

"Looks like the Zhuge Clan managed to seal the gap completely."

"With a formation?"

"What else would they use? Rocks?"

"Oh, come on. Why *couldn't* they use rocks?"

"Because that wouldn't solve the problem. And if rocks were enough, they'd have sealed it ages ago. Think before you speak."

"Oh, really? Is thinking too much why you shit yourself?"

"A dog that pissed itself criticizing a dog that shit itself."

"Pissing is better than shitting. Besides, Young Hero Gung did it twice. Last time, when we went to dispose of the imugi's corpse…"

"This is driving me crazy. I told you, that wasn't me!"

Hyuk Mujin clicked his tongue as Gung Gibang thumped his chest.

"There's only so much you can deny."

"I'm telling you the truth!"

"If it wasn't Young Hero Gung, then who was it? Hmm? Surely you don't think Perfected Being Hyeongong did it?"

"Jin Taekyung! I swear that bastard reeked of shit—gah!"

Gung Gibang broke off with a start and looked around. Only a few days earlier, he had been beaten half to death after having a similar conversation.

"He's not here, is he?"

Hyuk Mujin swallowed dryly as well.

The Jin Taekyung he knew had a fiery personality. Whoever started the insults, he would happily beat both sides senseless.

"P-probably?"

"You're sure?"

"How would I know? Anyone who can sense the Captain coming is already a Supreme Peak master. Or a ghost."

The two of them looked around with every sense on high alert, then let out deep sighs of relief.

Suddenly, the absurdity of their situation struck them. They had become afraid after saying only a few words.

“How long do we have to live like this?”

“Until the Captain dies.”

“What if he undergoes Returned to Youth[2366] someday?”

“Then we bite our tongues and kill ourselves. What else can we do?”

“Damn it. That Jin Taekyung bastard is a real monster. How can anyone be like that?”

Hyuk Mujin nodded vigorously. He’d known Jin Taekyung since his days as a delinquent; of course he understood.

“That’s true. And there are two of them, not just one.”

“Cheongpung? Don’t even get me started. After seeing the Drunken Eight Immortals Fist[2367] only a few times, he started imitating it pretty closely. If my master found out, he’d try to kill me for leaking our sect’s secret art.”

“Ooh.”

“…I have a fairly good idea what you were just thinking, but keep your mouth shut forever. I’m really going to die.”

“Oooh.”

“You rotten bastard.”

Gung Gibang shook his head, then asked, “What’s your lord doing, anyway? I hardly see him.”

“How would I know? He might be training. Might not. Some days he stays in his tent the whole time.”

“Sir Jin’s always busy with one thing or another. But Sir Jeok’s been gone a long time too.”

Jeok Cheongang had vanished without a trace after their first day there.

Plenty of people wondered where he was. None worried about his safety.

Fire King. Those two words were proof enough of what he could do.

“Who could harm the Fire King?”

“True. Even Dark Heaven wouldn’t dare. If they tried anything, three or four of their pillars would have been ripped out, and the surrounding area would already have been reduced to ashes.”

Gung Gibang nodded in agreement and continued.

“Come to think of it, I haven’t seen much of Mungyeong lately either.”

[2366] *Returned to Youth* refers to a martial-arts fantasy transformation in which an aged master regains a youthful body.

[2367] The Eight Immortals are legendary figures in Chinese Daoist tradition; the martial art’s name also invokes drunken boxing.

“Neither have I. Whenever I do see him, he’s with the Captain.”

“Really?”

“Yes. I figured it might be because the Captain got hurt while training…”

“Hmm.”

“What?”

“Nothing. I smell something.”

“Did you shit yourself again?”

“Hyuk Mujin, you lunatic. Not that. I mean there’s something going on between them.”

Gung Gibang frowned in thought.

“Wait. Could it be?”

“Could what?”

“You still don’t get it? Why have those two been together so often lately?”

Hyuk Mujin’s expression changed. Listening to Gung Gibang, he began to see what he meant.

“Then maybe…”

“Exactly what you’re thinking.”

“Good heavens. How can this be?”

“If you think about it, it is strange. The Captain punches us whenever he gets bored, but he hasn’t used so much as a single act of violence against Mungyeong.”

“He hardly even curses at him anymore. And something was suspicious when we went to deal with the imugi’s corpse.”

“When Jin Taekyung disappeared, Mungyeong was gone too.”

“Exactly! The Beggars’ Sect’s future Sect Leader never disappoints!”

“That settles it. Mungyeong…”

Gung Gibang’s face went rigid.

“He must be learning martial arts from that Jin bastard.”

“Ah, Mungyeong! How could you make such a terrible choice?”

Hyuk Mujin was genuinely heartbroken. Mungyeong was like a clean white sheet of paper. The thought of Jin Taekyung’s ink soaking into it made his chest ache.

“What did that child ever do to deserve this?”

“What a tragedy. How can I face the Divine Physician in Sichuan?”

“Not Mungyeong! We can’t let him go down the same path we did!”

“It’s too late. Jin Taekyung is a Fiend. Now that Mungyeong is in that evil bastard’s clutches, there’s nothing we can do.”

“Then by now, Mungyeong must be…”

“Haa…”

“Ah…”

The two of them sighed in dismay at the same time. Thinking of Mungyeong, who must by now be fighting for his life under Jin Taekyung's evil clutches, they felt their hearts grow heavy.

Please survive, Mungyeong.

Please, somebody save me.

Slice!

A gust of wind brushed my neck.

The pain was as cold as ice, then immediately flared hot. A bead of cold sweat ran down my forehead and dropped onto the ground with a soft tap.

Swish, tap!

I righted myself in midair and stared straight ahead.

"That was a little dangerous."

A voice answered—or rather, a Sound Transmission.

—It was meant to be.

"No, I'm serious. I almost died."

—Glad to hear it.

Where the hell is he?

I looked all around, but I couldn't see him. There was only that Sound Transmission, coming from nowhere I could pin down.

"Fucking hell."

—What kind of hell?

I took a deep breath and tightened my grip on White Flame's shaft.

Toward whoever was watching me from somewhere unseen, I muttered as though spitting the words out.

"This is so fucking shitty I can't keep doing this."

Whoosh!

Instead of an answer, a blinding sword strike came flying at me.

Chapter 497

Half an hour.

That was the longest I could hold out. With the cold edge of a sword against the back of my neck, I muttered under my breath.

“God, this sucks.”

Ssshhk.

A stinging pain ran across my neck, and blood slid down it. The point of the gesture was obvious. I sighed.

“I lost. Let’s stop.”

“Wrong. Again.”

That dry voice was one I hadn’t heard during the fight. I already knew what its owner wanted me to say.

“…I’m dead. Happy?”

The blade that had been slowly digging into my neck stopped. When I felt the cold metal withdraw, I pressed a hand to the cut to stop the bleeding, then turned around.

Mungyeong was sitting on a rock about thirty feet away.

“Do you know how many times you’ve died?”

“Twelve.”

Five times, my Sinews and Meridians had been severed in all four limbs. Three times, I had died from a Pressure-Point Strike to a lethal acupoint. Three more times, my heart had been pierced. And just now, my throat had been cut.

I hadn’t actually died, but I might as well have. I wiped the sticky blood from my neck with my sleeve and looked at Mungyeong.

“It’ll be different next time.”

“That’s the eleventh time I’ve heard that.”

“I mean it this time.”

“That makes twelve.”

“…”

What a memory.

As I stood there speechless, Mungyeong asked, “Do you know why you died?”

A fight always left a result, and a result gave you something to think about.

I silently replayed our fight in my head, then blurted out an answer.

“Because I fought like an assassin?”

“As expected, you know nothing… Hmm.”

Mungyeong had begun speaking almost at the same time as me, but now he trailed off.

“Am I wrong?”

“Go on.”

“I don’t know exactly when it started, but I found myself imitating you. Your movements and things like that.”

At first, after getting turned into a pickle soaked in poison, I’d begun paying attention to everything around me. Then I’d started copying Mungyeong’s movements bit by bit.

Dueling him two or three times a day, I’d gradually grown used to them. My eyes recognized them, and so did my body.

But…

“That was my mistake.”

“Why?”

“New shoes rub your heels raw. Even more so if they’re too small.”

“Be more specific.”

“I should’ve quit the clumsy imitation and fought my own way. Especially against the Slaughter Saint.”

“…”

Mungyeong stared at me for a while, then tossed out a single remark.

“You’re not a complete idiot.”

“Oh, was that a compliment?”

“It means you’ve only just reached the basics.”

“Exactly. Thank you for the compliment.”

Mungyeong frowned.

“Are your ears plugged?”

“Nope. They work fine.”

“…You have a gift for getting on people’s nerves.”

“Either way, reaching the basics means it was a compliment. Why are you so bad at being honest? Are you going through puberty?”

“I said I’m not!”

“Why are you shouting all of a sudden?”

“When did I— I said I’m not!”

“…Now that I think about it, maybe you are.”

Not going through puberty, my ass.

But if I talked back one more time, my head looked liable to fly off.

After that outburst, Mungyeong returned to his usual calm, dry tone as though nothing had happened.

“The basics are just that: the basics. There have been plenty of others like you.”

Others like me?

I ventured a question.

“Do you have other Disciples?”

“Of course. You met one in Sichuan.”

“Other than Old Man Dong. You know what I mean. Don’t change the subject.”

“…”

Silence was as good as an admission. The thought of the Slaughter Saint’s hidden Disciples made me curious.

“Who? Who are they? Do you still keep in touch? Do you all get together for a meal on Teacher’s Day[2368]?”

“I have no reason to tell you. And what the hell is Teacher’s Day?”

“You’re awfully difficult.”

“…You grow more insolent by the day. Do you have five lives or something?”

“Considering I’ve died and come back twelve times, I’d say I have about thirteen. So you’re really not going to tell me?”

Mungyeong stared at me, then spoke abruptly.

“I’ll tell you. On one condition.”

A condition from the Slaughter Saint. I answered with complete confidence.

“It’s about time to eat. I’ll be going now.”

“I distinctly remember you eating before you came.”

“I eat five meals a day.”

“Stay and hear the condition. You seemed quite curious.”

“Everyone has a life of their own and secrets they’d rather keep. Who am I to pry? Anyway, I’ll be off.”

“Stop right there if you want to keep your head.”

“…”

Fuck. I shouldn’t have asked.

My stomach knotted with panic as I turned back around. Fine. Since I was stuck here, I might as well hear the story.

“So you really have other Disciples?”

“Not Disciples. But I did teach several people.”

“That sounds like you’re saying they’re gone.”

“It’s been a very long time. They couldn’t possibly still be alive.”

“Were they, by any chance, in the same line of work as…?”

“They were assassins. They belonged to Salcheonmun[2369] with me.”

Even the name smelled of blood.

[2368] Teacher’s Day is a Korean holiday observed on May 15 to honor teachers.

[2369] *Salcheonmun* is the name of the now-vanished assassin sect; it literally means “Slaughter Heaven Sect.”

So he belonged to a sect, too.

It made sense when I thought about it. No matter how extraordinary Mungyeong was, he hadn't been born an assassin.

Still, a sect the Slaughter Saint belonged to should be fairly well known.

But no matter how thoroughly I searched my memory, the name Salcheonmun meant nothing to me.

As if he'd read my mind, Mungyeong spoke.

"No use trying to remember it. The sect vanished long ago."

There was only one way for a sect to vanish. Watching his expression, I carefully said one word.

"Annihilated?"

"Yes."

"How did that happen? No, before that—weren't you the Sect Leader?"

"They chose the wrong path and paid the price. That's all I'll say."

Mungyeong finished speaking and rose to his feet. A short sword in his hand already gleamed with a keen blue edge.

"Now it's time for you to pay."

"Excuse me?"

"Dodge one sword stroke. That's the condition."

Most people would probably think, *How am I supposed to evade that?* But from my perspective, it was worth trying.

I'd lasted half an hour against the Slaughter Saint while doing a lousy imitation of an assassin. Surely I could dodge one stroke.

"If I do, will you tell me more later?"

"Of course."

"Fine. I can do that."

Mungyeong added, "Close your eyes."

"Fuck. Are you kidding me?"

"Then you will die. Not the thirteenth time, but for the first and last time."

Before he'd finished speaking, Mungyeong's sleeve fluttered.

By now, I was used to his attacks. I instinctively turned my head, but what came flying toward me wasn't a hidden weapon. It was something else.

That's…

A powder so fine I could barely make it out even when I strained my eyes to their limit.

It rode the wind blowing toward me. The instant the powder touched the air—

Whoosh!

Darkness swallowed the world.

No. That wasn't right.

The darkness hadn't swallowed the world. It had swallowed me.

Beep.

SYSTEM

You have been poisoned by Blindness Powder!
You temporarily lose your eyesight!
Rapid Detoxification is required! If Detoxification is delayed too long, permanent damage may occur!

Every hair on my body stood on end as the System alert sounded in my ears.

Blindness Powder? The poison itself didn't matter. I was still wearing the Myriad-Poison Ring.

The problem was that Mungyeong's sword was coming through the darkness far faster than the ring could detoxify the Blindness Powder.

Ssshhk.

I couldn't see a thing. But I could feel it clearly.

In a world moving so slowly it felt as though someone had pressed pause, a killing sword approached, erasing the wind in its path.

This is…

A move from the greatest assassin of all time.

I felt a killing intent unlike anything I'd ever encountered—so stealthy and chilling that I shuddered.

I stared blankly into the darkness.

And in that suffocating space where I could see nothing, I felt every sense I had awaken.

Slash!

Wudang, the Zhuge Clan, and the Beggars' Sect.

They had chosen only trustworthy elites to preserve secrecy, but no one could ignore either the standing or the number of those gathered.

Among the several hundred martial artists from prestigious great sects, the figure of a young medical apprentice was bound to stand out wherever he went.

"Oh, it's you. Just coming out?"

"I've just been to see Young Master Jin."

"You seem to visit him more often these days."

"Yes. His training has been so rough lately that he keeps getting hurt."

"Good heavens. Great Hero Jin really is remarkable. He's younger than my son, but he isn't content with his current realm. He just keeps working…"

"He must be an incredible master. I don't know much about Murim myself."

The Zhuge martial artist standing guard let out a short laugh at the young medical apprentice's innocent remark. Boredom had led him to bother a child who'd learned nothing but medicine, and now he felt a little guilty.

"He is incredible. No doubt about it. You'll understand someday, too."

"Hmm. Is that so?"

"If you're not involved in Murim, you might not know. Anyway, is his training over for today?"

As though he knew nothing, Mungyeong tilted his head and answered.

"No. He said no one should come near him for the next two shichen[2370]."

"Understood. This is Great Hero Jin we're talking about—we can't interrupt his training. I'll pass that along to the next guards."

"Yes. Then take care."

Mungyeong politely bowed at the waist and was about to leave when the martial artist suddenly spoke.

"My, his training must be rougher than I thought."

"Sorry?"

"The blood on your sleeve. Was Great Hero Jin badly hurt?"

The guard's follow-up question never reached Mungyeong. He looked down at the bloodstain on his sleeve and murmured, "The basics…?"

"Hmm?"

"Oh, it's nothing. Young Master Jin is fine, so don't worry."

"Ah. Good. All right."

Leaving the martial artist behind with an uneasy expression, Mungyeong walked away.

Several faces had grown familiar enough to speak to him and acknowledge him as they passed, but the young medical apprentice's mind held only one person.

Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung…

He'd thought it couldn't happen. Yet the boy really had dodged that final sword stroke.

The results of the past several days of testing, and of today, had exceeded Mungyeong's expectations. No, they had exceeded anything he'd imagined.

So this can happen.

Everything he'd told Jin Taekyung was true.

[2370] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

He had once had people who could properly be called Disciples, and every one of them had possessed the “basics.”

But there was one thing he hadn’t mentioned: how long that had taken.

The fastest of them took a little over a year, if I remember right.

Jin Taekyung had done it in only seven days and nights.

No one else came close.

Mungyeong didn’t know whether it was because of the boy’s Heavenly Martial Physique or because he was a Supreme Peak master. Whatever the reason, there was something special about Jin Taekyung himself.

“Even so… I never expected this much.”

He murmured too softly for anyone to hear and rolled up his sleeve.

The skin had been cut by something sharp, and beads of blood had formed along the wound. Looking at it, Mungyeong had a sudden thought.

Now I understand how the Fire King feels.

But Mungyeong did not realize that a faint smile had formed at the corner of his mouth.

Chapter 498

The moment I woke from my long sleep, one thought flashed through my mind.

Don’t tell me the poison still hasn’t worn off.

Everything was black.

My flicker of unease faded as soon as I spotted the moon shining faintly in the ink-dark sky. I muttered, my voice hoarse, “Shit. You could’ve woken me before you left.”

I’d thought the Blindness Powder was still working. It was just night.

A good deal of time must have passed while I was unconscious. I lay sprawled on my back, staring blankly at the sky, then slowly sat up.

What the hell happened?

I had moved almost entirely unconsciously, and since I’d passed out while poisoned by the Blindness Powder, I hadn’t seen what happened at the time. I felt my dirt-covered body all over.

Nothing else seems to be hurt. I must have stopped it somehow.

I could guess the result, but I couldn’t picture how I’d done it. How had I moved? No matter how hard I tried to recall the sensation, the memory stayed hazy.

There was one thing I did know.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Mission: Earn Mungyeong's Recognition (Complete)
The Sudden Quest, Fake Murim Martial Artist, has been successfully completed!
The Quest completion Reward has been issued!
You have gained a considerable amount of EXP!
You have gained 10 points!
You have achieved the Outstanding Achievement, Deadly Poison Sommelier!
You have tasted and detoxified more than ten types of specially manufactured deadly poison. We salute your sturdy body and Detoxification ability!
Poison Resistance increases significantly!
You have achieved the Amazing Achievement, Wow, You Survived That!
At the crossroads between life and death, you grasped a clue to a new enlightenment!
Qi Sense becomes sharper. Train to advance to an even higher realm!
The Follow-up Quest, Fake Murim Martial Artist—Stage 2, has been created!
The objective of the Follow-up Quest will be determined by Mungyeong's future plans!
Agh!

"Agh," my ass. As someone who had nearly crossed the Jordan River[2371] instead of Dongting Lake, I was furious.

A Follow-up Quest.

I'd expected something like this, but that didn't make it any less worrying. Stage 1 had me dodge the Slaughter Saint's sword stroke with my eyes closed. What kind of fucked-up stunt did they have planned for Stage 2?

At least the rewards were generous.

I guess putting my body through hell paid off.

I hadn't leveled up, but I'd gained a considerable amount of EXP and recovered the points I'd lost after being poisoned by Seven-Step Soul-Chasing Powder.

And…

Which asshole came up with those titles?

Deadly Poison Sommelier and Wow, You Survived That. The names pissed me off, but both Achievements were worth having.

[2371] "Crossing the Jordan River" is used here to mean dying, in contrast to crossing Dongting Lake.

The Poison Resistance from the first one was obviously welcome. The second might seem a little vague right now, but it was a huge gift.

A clue to enlightenment.

I'd been feeling as though I'd hit a wall lately. Nothing could have been better news. Of course, if I said that out loud after racing through the realms on the Fire Gate Clan's Supreme Peak martial arts and quarterly helpings of elixirs, Murim would probably declare me a public enemy.

Still, a wall's a wall.

Ask a martial artist stuck at Second Rate or Third Rate what they need, and nine out of ten will say martial arts manuals and elixirs. Ask a master who's reached Peak or higher, and the answer changes.

Enlightenment.

Ten years, twenty years—even longer could pass without it coming. No matter how extraordinary the martial arts you learned or how many elixirs you took, there was a limit to how far they could carry you.

If stuffing yourself with elixirs could make you a Supreme Peak master and return you to youth, who would train until they bled and sweated? People devoted their lives to training because they couldn't get past that wall any other way.

Gung Gibang had once told me that quite a few martial artists even took opium, hoping to expand the realm of their minds and attain enlightenment.

When I asked why they'd do something so stupid, his answer was simple.

"They know they'll get addicted to opium if they keep it up."

"Then why do it?"

"Because they're martial artists."

A short answer, but it explained everything.

Martial artists were creatures like that. They were the sort of people who would do anything if it meant becoming stronger. They were more intoxicated by martial arts than by opium, and they had become addicted to power.

And I wasn't so different.

I want to be stronger. Stronger still.

I had more now than I could ever have imagined in the past, and I still wanted more strength. There was one crucial difference between me and other martial artists, though. I didn't want it so I could gain something. I wanted it so I could protect what I had.

If I'd been satisfied with where I was, I never would've accepted Mungyeong's training.

That made the clue to enlightenment an enormous gain.

There was just one tiny problem.

Doctor, I don't remember a thing.

I didn't even know what I'd done. Fuck.

Seriously, how had I pulled it off? I thought I'd dodged the sword by a hair, but I couldn't remember what happened after that.

Maybe I'll figure it out if I keep training.

I tried to recapture the sensation, but for now I was groping through fog. I sighed, got to my feet, and began brushing the dirt off my clothes.

That was when it happened.

Ssshhk—boom!

Far away, a streak of blue fire shot into the dark sky and burst in a brilliant flash.

A signal firework?

I hurried out of the training area to see what was going on and found the martial artists standing guard.

"What happened?"

"Oh, Great Hero Jin. You're finally out."

The Beggars' Sect disciple shrugged. His patched clothes and the two knots hanging from his waist marked him as a member of the Hubei branch.

"Blue means visitors. We knew they were coming, but they're later than expected."

"Visitors?"

What is this place, a tourist attraction?

Since the place was being treated as highly classified, I couldn't immediately think of anyone who might come here. At most, there were the three sects gathered here and the authorities. And if they were sending reinforcements, the guards wouldn't call them visitors.

"Where from? The Zhuge Clan? Wudang? Oh, did Wudang's Sect Leader finally arrive?"

"Sorry?"

The Beggars' Sect disciple and the other martial artists stared at me as if they had never seen such a strange person before.

"Uh… you haven't heard?"

"Heard what?"

"Who's coming."

"What are you talking about…? Is it someone I know?"

The disciple nodded.

"Yes. They're from the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"…Huh?"

From where?

Splash! Splish, splash!

Disciplined footsteps crossed the moonlit river and left fresh tracks in the sand.

Around fifty martial artists moved as one, forming lines on either side. A man walked slowly between them, spotted me, and stopped.

“It’s been a long time.”

His eyes were as sharp as ever, and he had more scars than I remembered. I gave a short laugh at the familiar face I hadn’t seen in a year.

“Your face looks even fiercer. Maybe we should call you Ghost Face instead of Ghost Sword.”

“There were plenty of bastards who needed dealing with. As our family’s reach has grown, all sorts have come crawling out of the woodwork.”

“Just tell me who. I’ll deal with them.”

“There’s no need. They’ve already left for a place beyond anyone’s reach. And…”

His narrowed eyes held a smile, and his voice carried both fondness and joy.

“There’s no need for the Divine Dragon to bother with mere cows and pigs.”

Ghost Sword Wipeng—Jin Wikyung’s right-hand man and the person once charged with knocking some sense into me—gave me a deep martial salute.

“Wipeng, Commander of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, greets the Third Young Master.”

“Greetings, Third Young Master!”

The shout rang out through the stillness of the deep night. Powerful energy radiated from the bodies of the martial artists standing in lines like iron towers on either side. They were just like the two characters embroidered across every one of their chests: Jin Dragon.

Wow. When did the Jin Family of Taiyuan get this big?

It felt like yesterday that we’d sat with our heads together, muttering that we were fucked because we had nowhere near enough First Rate masters for the war against the Mount Heng Sword Sect. Yet the weakest member of the Jin Dragon Squad standing before me was at least First Rate.

Just looking at them gets me fired up.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had been slowly declining: the Family Head had been absent for years, we were desperately short on people, and the Third Young Master liked pleasure houses more than his own home. And that was only part of it.

Seeing how far the family had risen made my chest swell with pride.

Is this why people build families?

I was gazing at Wipeng and the Jin Dragon Squad when a voice behind him spoiled the moment.

“Hey, damn it! You startled me. Why are you all shouting in the middle of the night? What if an old man with a weak heart like mine drops dead from the shock?”

That seemed unlikely.

I studied the man’s muscles—hard to believe they belonged to an old man—and finally dredged up the memory.

“Always do Taebo?”[2372]

Jang Taebo, former Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild, scowled.

“Listen to the mouth on this brat. Am I your friend?”

I’d built up quite a reputation over the past year, but Jang Taebo, a master craftsman who never held back, didn’t seem to care. If anything, that made me even happier to see him. Besides, White Flame, the spear he’d put his heart into forging, had saved my life more than once.

“Seriously, Elder. What brings you here?”

The answer came from someone other than Jang Taebo.

“I asked him to come.”

The people who had hurried over after hearing that the Jin Family of Taiyuan had arrived murmured among themselves and parted to either side. Jin Wikyung came through the crowd, and a shout even louder than before rang out.

“Wipeng, Commander of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, pays his respects to his lord.”

“Loyalty!”

“That’s enough.”

Under different circumstances, Jin Wikyung would have grabbed Wipeng’s hand and danced a waltz with him, but countless eyes were watching us. Wearing a solemn, dignified expression, he waved a hand and continued in his deep voice.

“Commander of the Jin Dragon Squad. And Old Master Jang. You’ve both had a difficult journey.”

“Not at all, my lord.”

“Don’t concern yourself with this old man, Lesser Family Head.”

Wipeng was obviously a trusted retainer, but even Jang Taebo, who called me this brat and that bastard, was unfailingly respectful toward Jin Wikyung. I’d heard he had retired ages ago. Had he started taking work from the Jin Family of Taiyuan while I was away?

Leaving my question unanswered, Jin Wikyung spoke again.

“The journey must have been tiring. Let’s all move somewhere else first.”

[2372] A Korean catchphrase urging people to “always do Tae Bo,” used here as a pun on Jang Taebo’s name.

I could tell I was included in that “all.” I could also tell the man running toward us, panting hard, wasn’t.

“Hyuk Mujin, Vice Commander of the Jin Dragon Squad! I’ve just finished my guard duty and returned!”

“…”

Some guard duty.

If you’re going to lie, wipe the sleep from your eyes first, you bastard.

Chapter 499

Spring was in full swing, but the night wind blowing along Dongting Lake's winding waterways was chilly.

Jang Taebo entered Jin Wikyung's heavy-cloth tent, claimed the spot in front of the brazier, and sat down to warm himself.

"Whew. Now I feel alive."

Jin Wikyung smiled and handed him a cup of tea.

"You've had a long journey."

"Good thing I happened to be in Henan. If I'd been in Shanxi, I wouldn't have come even at your request, Lesser Family Head. Working an old man who's just waiting to die this hard…"

I looked at Jang Taebo's threatening muscles and thought,

He looks plenty capable of hard work…

Just look at him. He wasn't merely fit; he was built. While overwork shaved years off other people's lives, the worst it could do to Jang Taebo was cost him some muscle.

Wipeng seemed to be thinking along the same lines. He glanced from his own forearm to Jang Taebo's, then spoke.

"I heard everything that happened in Sichuan and Hubei. I came myself to see if all was well and settle the matter in Henan while I was at it. It seems my timing was good."

Jin Wikyung laughed heartily and patted Wipeng on the shoulder.

"Wipeng. You truly are my Zhang Liang!"[2373]

"I'm a martial artist."

"Oh. Then Han Xin."

"Han Xin was purged in the end."

"Xiao He, then."

"Xiao He was a civil official too."

"…"

Jin Wikyung looked at Wipeng as though he wanted to purge him on the spot, then cleared his throat.

"Ahem. It seems you've had a great deal bottled up."

In an ordinary relationship between lord and retainer, Wipeng would have denied it. But he was one of the few people who could openly give Jin Wikyung a hard time.

"Yes, my lord. Did you not know?"

[2373] Zhang Liang, Han Xin, and Xiao He were three founding ministers of the Han dynasty. Han Xin was a military commander; Zhang Liang and Xiao He were civil officials.

“I knew, but I didn’t expect you to come all this way to tell me.”

“I didn’t come of my own accord. You summoned me. Do you realize you’ve been away for nearly three months? Not long ago, even Sect Leader Lee came to ask whether something had happened to you.”

“Cough, cough!”

The way Jin Wikyung kept clearing his throat suggested he had plenty to feel guilty about.

Wait. Sect Leader Lee? Wipeng couldn’t mean…

“Are you talking about Young Lady Lee—Lee Seowol?”

Wipeng shook his head.

“Not Young Lady. She is the bona fide Sect Leader of an established sect, Third Young Master.”

“Oh. Right.”

The Mount Heng Sword Sect had once sought to become the dominant power in Shanxi Province, only to collapse after a series of disasters.

However, Lee Seowol, the only surviving blood relative of the Blood Wolf Sword, had survived with my help and sworn loyalty to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Vassal or not, a Sect Leader was still a Sect Leader.

When did I last see her…? Has it been over a year already?

It was around the time Jeok Cheongang and I left the Jin Family of Taiyuan for Mount Jiuhua. A year had passed in Murim alone. Counting my time in the modern world, it had been even longer.

I could still remember our parting clearly.

“Excuse me, Sect Leader Lee.”

“Young Lady.”

“Pardon?”

“Please call me Young Lady.”

“Ah, yes. Young Lady Lee, then.”

“Go ahead, Young Master Jin.”

“May peace prevail throughout your household.”

“…”

“And may your sect prosper too. Whatever you do, I hope it all goes well.”

Hmm. I thought we’d parted on a fairly warm note.

The Lee Seowol I remembered had the resolve you’d expect of a martial family’s daughter. She hadn’t backed down even when Pung Yang came at her with the Red Wind Band. The ruined Mount Heng Sword Sect must have recovered quite a bit by now.

“So, is Young Lady Lee doing well these days?”

Wipeng considered the question.

“In some respects, yes. In others, perhaps not.”

“Why? Is something going wrong?”

“If you’re asking about the sect, the Mount Heng Sword Sect has already completed its reconstruction. Under Sect Leader Lee’s command, it is growing rapidly, and the number of its disciples is increasing every day.”

“Oh.”

“Great Hero Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng and a friend of her late father, has also ended his seclusion and is taking an active role in the affairs of the Mount Heng Sword Sect.”

“Ohh.”

Then everything was going well, wasn’t it?

Wipeng narrowed his eyes at my puzzled look.

“Third Young Master, forgive me for asking, but have you truly not contacted her once since then?”

“Contacted her? About what?”

“…Hah. Never mind. Pretend you didn’t hear that.”

The mood had turned strange. Jang Taebo clicked his tongue beside me, and a thought flashed through my mind.

No way. Come on, it can’t be. But what if…? No. That’s not it.

Jin Wikyung rescued me from my sudden confusion with a single remark.

“I’m glad to hear Sect Leader Lee is doing well. What about my second brother? I haven’t seen him in months.”

Wipeng gave me a look usually reserved for a pill bug, then sighed.

“He’s much the same. He lives on the fasting pills stored in the training hall and hasn’t set foot outside.”

“Mukyung, that fool. What is he trying to do…?”

Jin Wikyung had reason to worry.

Before I left for Mount Jiuhua, Jin Mukyung had lost a duel to Cheongpung. From that day on, he’d shut himself in the training hall and refused to come out.

A year had passed. The Star-Array Grand Banquet had been held, and Dark Heaven’s shadow now hung over Murim. He was still in there.

He did say he wouldn’t come out until he’d accomplished something great.

There was a time when all of Murim called Jin Mukyung a once-in-a-millennium genius.

Even the direct disciples of the Nine Sects and One Gang, with their generous supply of exceptional martial arts and elixirs, couldn’t compare to him. Despite being born into a fallen martial family on the fringes, Jin Mukyung had risen to the forefront of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes on the strength of his martial arts alone.

And then he met Cheongpung.

For Jin Mukyung, Cheongpung's existence must have been an enormous shock and an equally enormous stimulus. The fact that he was still training in seclusion more than a year later was proof of it.

He'll accomplish something. I'm sure of it.

The Jin Mukyung I knew was a genius, no question.

He hadn't had the Sword Saint to teach him, or exceptional elixirs and martial arts handed to him. He'd come this far on his own. I couldn't imagine what he might be like when he finally emerged.

The question is when.

He wasn't going to emerge when he was nearly sixty, was he?

If he survived on nothing but fasting pills until then, I'd genuinely respect him and treat him as my hyung.[2374] Frankly, a full year of eating those tasteless things was impressive enough.

Even Wudang Daoists brought jerky instead of fasting pills when they practiced wall-facing meditation. What did that tell you?

One bite of a fasting pill, and even the worst vegetarians—the kind who flip over the grill at a barbecue restaurant—would go looking for pork belly.

While I was thinking about that, the conversation had moved on to Jang Taebo.

"By the way, Lesser Family Head, will you tell this old man why you summoned him?"

In response to Jang Taebo's grumbling question, Jin Wikyung abruptly tossed out a single phrase.

"Ironcraft Hall. What do you think?"

"I've never heard of such a place in the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"You wouldn't have. It was established only a few days ago."

Jang Taebo frowned.

"It's a strangely familiar name. It reminds me of the Ironcraft Guild, where this old man once worked."

"I named it with you in mind, Old Master Jang. Master of Ironcraft Hall. Has a nice ring to it, doesn't it?"

"Lesser Family Head."

Jang Taebo sighed.

"I left the Ironcraft Guild long ago."

"Then perhaps it's time you came back."

"I'm old and tired. I haven't the strength to lift a hammer."

[2374] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he is close to.

Jin Wikyung stared meaningfully at Jang Taebo's threatening muscles, then moved his lips.

"Youngest."

By now, I knew exactly why he'd summoned Jang Taebo. I tapped White Flame, strapped across my back, and let it fall.

Clang!

"Oh no! I dropped a divine weapon made by a blacksmith too old and tired to lift a hammer!"

"…"

"My spear, made from Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron! They say it's incredibly difficult to work. I wonder who made it…"

Jang Taebo glared at me as though he wanted to tear me apart.

"Enough."

"Why? I wasn't talking about you, Elder."

"I made it, didn't I?"

"What are you talking about? How could someone who can't lift a hammer make this?"

"…That damned brat."

Jang Taebo sighed as though the ground itself had collapsed, then looked at Jin Wikyung.

"Was this why you gave me all sorts of help?"

"Of course not. It was a simple kindness to the artisan who made a divine weapon for my beloved youngest brother."

"Then I'll answer your proposal."

"I'm listening."

"No. That is the only answer this old man can give. It wouldn't change with a blade at my throat."

I shot my hand up.

"What about the spear?"

"Shut up before I take it back and snap it."

"Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. Special feature: fucking hard."

"…Why did I ever make a spear for a bastard like you? What riches and glory did I think I'd get out of it?"

"Just become the Master of Ironcraft Hall. I hear you've had plenty of help from our family."

"I'll repay you with money. Do you think I'm going to put myself through that kind of hell again at my age?"

"Seriously? You really won't do it?"

"Then what are you going to do? I said I wouldn't."

"Then just tell me your conditions. I'll meet as many of them as I can."

"Conditions?"

A smug smile appeared on Jang Taebo's face.

"Remember this time last year? I'll set the same conditions."

"The conditions from back then? You can't mean…"

"The Herb of Eternal Youth, gongcheong seokyu,[2375] a dragon's claw, or a dragon pearl. Bring me any one of those."

Beep.

SYSTEM

A Sudden Quest, No Way You Can Do It Anyway, has been created!

Quest Objective: Obtain at least one of the items Jang Taebo named.

Clang! Crash!

I sprang to my feet and shouted.

"Come on! Where am I supposed to find any of that? You're asking for a dragon, not even an imugi!"[2376]

"Imugi[2377] or dragon, bring me one first. Then I'll bury my bones in the Jin Family of Taiyuan. If you can't, keep quiet."

Beep.

SYSTEM

Quest details have been changed.

Quest Objective: Obtain an imugi's[2378] claw.

I checked the changed System window and nodded.

"Oh, that works. Here."

"My mind hasn't changed, so don't waste your effort—what are you suddenly giving me?"

"An imugi's[2379] claw."

"Huh?"

[2375] *Gongcheong seokyu* is a rare elixir in martial-arts fiction. *Seokyu* also sounds like the Korean word for petroleum.

[2376] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with becoming a dragon.

[2377] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with becoming a dragon.

[2378] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with becoming a dragon.

[2379] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with becoming a dragon.

"An imugi's[2380] claw. You told me to bring you one."

"...What?"

Jang Taebo's pupils shook as though an earthquake had struck.

He was a Master Artisan ranked among the three greatest in the world, and he had once served as the Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild, the finest blacksmith organization under Heaven.

"An... an imugi's[2381] claw? Is it real?"

"Look at the length. It's obviously not one of mine."

"No, I mean, where in the world did you..."

"I caught it."

"What?"

"There are bones and scales too."

"That's impossible!"

"Go see for yourself after sunrise. Great Hero Wipeng's only heard about it in a letter, so you two can go together."

Beep.

SYSTEM

The Sudden Quest, No Way You Can Do It Anyway, has been successfully completed!

As a Quest Reward, the Jin Family of Taiyuan has acquired Jang Taebo!

Achievement unlocked: Wow, You Found It!

Along with the cheerful System notification, Jin Wikyung warmly put an arm around Jang Taebo's shoulder.

"I look forward to working with you from now on, Master of Ironcraft Hall."

"...!"

Jang Taebo's eyes were utterly vacant. The Jin Family of Taiyuan had acquired its very own Dobby[2382]—no, slave.

[2380] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with becoming a dragon.
[2381] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with becoming a dragon.
[2382] Dobby is an enslaved house-elf in the *Harry Potter* series.

Chapter 500

It was still dark when Jang Taebo followed us out, looking as though he'd been led to his execution. The moment he saw the Water God Dragon's remains, his expression changed.

"Ohhh… Ohhhhh…!"

Talk about a change of attitude.

Trembling like a kindergartener who needed to pee, Jang Taebo threw himself between the mountains of bones and scales.

"Oh, the strength! The color!"

His eyes had gone hazy, and his voice shook. He ran his hands over the scales and stroked the bones, unable to contain his excitement.

"I'd be happy to be buried here and die! No, I want to die here!"

"Get the Old Master out of there! The pile's about to collapse!"

"Y-yes, sir!"

The Jin Dragon Squad martial artists had been staring blankly at the remains of a gigantic creature unlike anything they had ever seen. Now they rushed forward and dragged Jang Taebo out.

Only then did the old Master Artisan come to his senses. He looked at me with moist eyes.

"So everything you told me was true."

"It sounds insane, but every word of it was true."

"I thought I'd had my fill of working meteorite iron fallen from the sky and Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron…"

Jang Taebo wiped at his eyes. He sniffed, tried to compose himself, then seized my shoulder.

"Thank you. Now I can die without regrets."

I gave him a warm look.

"Don't say that. Stay healthy and live a long life. Have something nourishing simmered for yourself, too."

"You little…"

"You still have plenty of Stamina and life left to grind into the forge. Where are you trying to run off to—the afterlife?"

"You little…!"

Same words. Different feeling.

A high-quality slave this hard to acquire deserved to be put to work. Toss him a reward now and then, crack the whip when needed.

Of course, I wasn't the one holding the whip.

“Well, would you look at that. Even the second time, it’s astonishing. And there’s so much of it.”

“Speak of the whip holder.”

“Hm? What was that, my youngest?”

“Nothing, eldest brother.”

Jin Wikyung tilted his head, then laughed and patted Jang Taebo on the back.

“What do you think, Hall Master Jang? Quite a sight, isn’t it?”

“Hall Master… Jang?”

“Of course. You’re the Master of our family’s Ironcraft Hall now. That makes you Hall Master Jang. Come, let’s hear your opinion.”

The reality Jang Taebo had briefly forgotten began to sink in. His face darkened.

“There’s no question it’s extraordinary. Even at the Ironcraft Guild, with the finest artisans and materials under Heaven gathered in one place, I never saw anything like this.”

“So, can you work with it?”

“I can’t promise anything until I try. But…”

Jang Taebo studied the mountain of remains before continuing.

“The bones are far stronger than meteorite iron, though not quite as strong as Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. They should be workable.”

“And the hide and scales?”

“I made enough armor in my younger days to get sick of it. None of it was made from an imugi[2383], of course… but I’ll try.”

“Oh!”

“With this much material, there will be enough to arm every martial artist in the Jin Family of Taiyuan—or rather, in our family—and still have some left over. I should be able to show results soon, so I trust you’ll forgive the first few failures.”

“Of course.”

Among artisans, Jang Taebo held a place equal to—or perhaps higher than—the Three Saints did among martial artists.

Jin Wikyung’s face lit up at the high-quality slave’s calm, well-founded confidence.

“I’ve heard that only the finest Master Artisan of his generation can lead the Ironcraft Guild. I’m counting on you, Hall Master Jang. Whatever you need, just say the word.”

“Then assign me some artisans I can rely on, Lesser Family Head.”

“Artisans?”

“I know our family has artisans of its own. If I train them, they may not become the beams that hold up the family, but they could make sturdy pillars. However…”

[2383] An imugi is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often depicted as a dragon that has yet to attain its full form.

“That would take time. Am I right?”

“Yes. I have eyes and ears, and I’ve heard what’s been happening across the world. The artisans I still keep in touch with tell me orders for weapons and armor have risen sharply.”

The war had already begun.

From the small and mid-sized sects scattered throughout Murim to the Nine Sects and One Gang,[2384] everyone wanted weapons and armor to prepare for the war that had drawn so close. The fires of the forges would not go out until the war ended.

In the current state of Murim, it was not only the flames of war that had begun to blaze fiercely.

“Time is short, Lesser Family Head.”

Jin Wikyung looked up at the sky in silence. Then he spoke.

“Hall Master Jang, how long have you been at this?”

“I started when I was shorter than your sword, Lesser Family Head. I’ve devoted my life to it.”

“Then after all those years in the trade, you must have made many friends.”

“Of course. Every one of them is a renowned artisan in their field.”

“Send messenger pigeons to everyone who comes to mind. I don’t care if it costs a fortune.”

“Everyone has something they value more than money. To an artisan like me, the body of an imugi[2385] is worth more than any fortune.”

Jang Taebo stepped back and gave Jin Wikyung a respectful martial salute.

“Jang Taebo, Master of Ironcraft Hall of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, obeys the Lesser Family Head’s command.”

By then, the darkness had retreated and the sun was rising on a new day. The light spreading from the east looked like the glow of a forge, and the quick footsteps of the Jin Dragon Squad martial artists carrying away the Water God Dragon’s remains beat like hammers.

While fifty Jin Dragon Squad martial artists transported the Water God Dragon’s remains under Wipeng and Jang Taebo’s meticulous direction, Jin Wikyung and I returned to where we were supposed to be. There we found Zhuge Feng beside himself with excitement.

“I did it! I’m telling you, I did it!”

[2384] The Nine Sects and One Gang are a grouping of major orthodox martial-arts organizations in Murim.

[2385] An imugi is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often depicted as a dragon that has yet to attain its full form.

He bounced around like a child, without a trace of the dignity expected of a clan's Family Head.

But once I saw what he'd done, I couldn't help nodding.

He blocked the magical power completely.

Unlike before, not even a trace of magical power escaped the enormous rift—or rather, the Gate.

The dogs, pigs, fish, and other animals apparently left there for testing showed an interest in it a few times, then went back to what they'd been doing.

"You really did it, Sir Zhuge," Jin Wikyung said.

A broad smile spread across Zhuge Feng's exhausted face.

"Of course I did. Even my ancestor Zhuge Wuhou[2386] couldn't have managed this. Come to think of it, he knew a thing or two about mechanisms and formations himself, but Wei still kicked his ass in the end…"

"F-Family Head!"

"What? It's true! If he really cared about the people and was such a great strategist, he should've thrown a resignation letter in that incompetent emperor's face instead of a campaign memorial, then taken the throne for himself…"

"Family Head, have you lost your mind?"

"No, Uncle. Am I wrong?"

The Zhuge Clan was a mess.

Having smeared shit all over his ancestor's reputation, the current Family Head shook off his relatives and continued proudly.

"Well? What do you think of the Demon-Sealing Formation now that you've seen it?"

"The Demon-Sealing Formation?"

Zhuge Feng nodded, pleased with himself.

"I named it. A formation that seals a demon's power. Fitting, isn't it?"

The Demon-Sealing Formation. Considering where that power came from, I couldn't think of a better name.

Not that the name mattered if the formation worked.

As I carefully examined the Demon-Sealing Formation, Jin Wikyung whispered to me.

"What do you think?"

"Of what?"

"…?"

"I'm just looking at it. How would I know?"

[2386] Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific for Zhuge Liang, chancellor of Shu Han during China's Three Kingdoms period. He fought Wei and wrote a memorial to his emperor before a military campaign.

Murim formations were much like modern magic circles. I'd encountered Magic plenty of times as a Hunter and still knew next to nothing about it. There was no way I could judge a formation at a glance.

I could at least sense the qi flowing through it.

Looks like it's drawing in qi from the natural world to block the magical power... The principle is similar to a magic circle.

Compared with modern magic circles, though, the formations I'd seen and heard about in Murim were much more limited in variety and power. Murim's emphasis on martial arts themselves probably had a lot to do with that.

They did this faster and better than I expected.

The natural qi flowing through the formation was enough to block the magical power leaking from the Gate completely. For now, it was the best solution we had.

After looking it over carefully, I turned to Zhuge Feng.

"How long will the Demon-Sealing Formation last?"

"Do you think the Yangtze will ever run dry?"

"Ah."

"It will keep drawing in the qi around it and continue operating. Assuming my theory is correct."

"And if it isn't?"

"My theory? You might as well call Zhuge Wuhou a halfwit."

Clang!

"You bastard, Zhuge Feng!"

"Great-Uncle, no! Put your sword down!"

"Someone shut the Family Head's mouth!"

The atmosphere had suddenly turned murderous.

Before blood could be spilled among the relatives, I hurried to speak to Zhuge Feng, who was using a grappling technique against the family members rushing him.

"Can you keep installing these?"

"Huh?"

"What?"

"What do you mean?"

For the benefit of the Zhuge Clan members who had stopped in their tracks, I said it again, slowly and clearly.

"Keep installing them. Dozens of times. Hundreds, if necessary."

"…!"

"…!"

The air around us instantly turned cold.

Zhuge Feng, who had been held by the collar by an old man, straightened his clothes. When he looked at me again, his eyes were steady and his voice had gone quiet.

"Now I'm curious what the Divine Dragon has in mind."

I clicked my tongue bitterly.

"It's obvious, isn't it? You already know, Sir Zhuge."

"I do. If it happened once, it could happen ten times. A hundred."

"Then we're thinking the same thing."

"I wasn't as certain as you. I was only considering every possibility."

Something unreadable flashed in Zhuge Feng's eyes.

"Why are you so certain that things like this will continue happening? What grounds do you have for speaking with such confidence?"

Plenty. I just couldn't tell him.

The Zhuge Clan might have celebrated when Zhuge Feng was born, but when I was born, all of humanity celebrated. The Demon King Asmodeus had fallen, and the long Great Cataclysm had ended.

There was no explaining the difference.

An entire lifetime—my lifetime—had passed since then. Yet Gates still existed in the modern world, and new ones kept appearing.

Once a dam starts to crack, no matter how sturdy it is, there's no telling how far the damage will spread.

That was Murim now.

I can't exactly tell them all of this.

In the end, there was only one answer I could give.

"I saw it and felt it in the memories the Water God Dragon passed on to me. Dark Heaven intended this from the start. They planned it and carried it out. And they'll keep doing it."

"You're a better liar than I expected."

"You're more suspicious than I expected."

"I can't believe you. No—that's not quite true. I don't want to."

"Zhuge Wuhou must have felt the same way. And yet he still served that stupid emperor until the very end. Even if it fucking sucks, you have to accept it."

"Even if it fucking sucks, you have to accept it…"

Zhuge Feng gave a short laugh and turned to Jin Wikyung.

"What do you think, Lesser Family Head?"

"I agree with my younger brother," Jin Wikyung said calmly.

"I do wonder what the others will think."

"Then why don't we ask them?"

“What does that mean…?”

Zhuge Feng studied Jin Wikyung. Then he murmured, “Henan.”

“Yes.”

Jin Wikyung looked into the distance.

“The New Murim Alliance.”

Chapter 501

“When is it?”

On the way back after parting with Zhuge Feng, I asked the question out of the blue. Jin Wikyung answered quietly.

“In a month. Mount Song, Henan Province.”

“Mount Song…”

The very place where Shaolin Temple—the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper[2387] of the Murim—stood.

Only three months ago, the Star-Array Grand Banquet, a grand gathering of the Murim under Heaven, had begun there. Dark Heaven had unleashed a storm of blood on that same ground. Now the New Murim Alliance would be born there.

Given the symbolism of Mount Song and Shaolin Temple, it was a fitting place for the Murim Alliance to begin again after more than fifty years.

But if there was only a month left…

“It had already been decided when you came to Sichuan, hadn’t it?”

Contrary to my expectations, Jin Wikyung gave a small shake of his head.

“It hadn’t?”

“Why do you think Wipeng happened to be in Henan at just the right time?”

“Then Great Hero Wipeng came because…”

“The Jin Dragon Squad is our family’s finest fighting force. As the Lesser Family Head, I would never summon half its members merely to serve as porters, even if they were carrying the Son of Heaven’s jade seal.[2388]”

“So the date was moved up.”

“Dark Heaven moved more aggressively, and faster, than we expected. The Sichuan Blood Tragedy was decisive.”

To catch an enemy who was ahead of you, you had to run.

The storm of blood that had swept through Shaolin Temple had spread to Sichuan and now reached Hubei. The leaders in Henan had to make a choice.

“Bringing the Murim under Heaven together is no easy task. But it seems they have finally made up their minds.”

Muttering quietly, Jin Wikyung pulled a sealed dispatch from inside his robes and held it out to me.

“What’s this?”

“A letter Wipeng brought from Henan.”

“From Henan? Did the Murim Alliance send it?”

[2387] Mount Tai and the Northern Dipper are symbols of eminence; together, they describe someone or something held in the highest regard in a field.

[2388] The emperor’s jade seal symbolized imperial authority.

"You guessed."

"I thought so. I saw you give one to Sir Zhuge earlier."

Even at a glance, it looked nothing like an ordinary letter.

But what made it special were the three characters written across its face in a bold, soaring hand:

Murim Alliance.

"Read it yourself, youngest."

"I'm already reading it, so stop talking. I can't concentrate."

"…Oh. Right."

Leaving Jin Wikyung looking dejected, I unfolded the letter and skimmed it.

It began, *To the Murim under Heaven,* and was short and forceful. That made it easy to sum up in three lines.

1. Hey, let me tell you about Dark Heaven. These guys are seriously fucking crazy, so listen up.
2. You remember the Great Faction War PTSD? Let's stop this by any means necessary.
3. Any dumbasses who don't know where Mount Song is? Be there by the stated date. Anyone who doesn't show up is Dark Heaven.

"…"

Put that way, it sounded pretty pathetic.

Of course, that was not what the letter actually said.

Some unknown calligrapher's bold strokes flowed like clouds. Every sentence was solemn, charged with feeling, and deeply moving.

Personally, I almost wanted to show it to that bastard, the Lord of Heaven.

If he saw this, even the Lord of Heaven might join the Murim Alliance.

Everyone could have enjoyed a happy ending if the Lord of Heaven joined the Murim Alliance. It was simply unfortunate that the possibility of that happening was less than the amount of earwax in Hyuk Mujin's ear.

"In any case, the Murim Alliance will be born soon."

"In a month, the Murim under Heaven will gather beneath the Murim Alliance's banner."

After a moment's thought, Jin Wikyung added, "Not the Murim under Heaven. I should say the orthodox Murim of the Central Plains."

I knew what he meant.

Right… It's a stretch to call the orthodox faction the whole Murim under Heaven.

The orthodox faction, led by the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, was unquestionably the dominant force in the Murim today.

But it had not been the only side to survive the Great Faction War and emerge victorious.

"The unorthodox faction."

Jin Wikyung nodded at my mutter.

"Yes. We cannot leave them out."

The fishbowl called the world held more than one color of fish.

The unorthodox faction was weak compared to the orthodox faction, but it had carved out territories of its own. It also included the dark-path figures who ruled the streets at night.

At first, I wondered why they had left those people alive while shouting about eliminating every demonic and heterodox element.

There was a reason for everything.

The unorthodox forces still around today had survived because they sided with the orthodox faction during the Great Faction War.

The trouble was, they had not done it out of goodwill.

"Do you know why the unorthodox forces now active in the Central Plains sided with the orthodox Murim?"

"You haven't forgotten who I've spent the past year with, have you?"

"Great Hero Jeok told you."

"I picked up quite a bit."

As the old saying went, green went with green, and crayfish took the crab's side.

When the Demonic Cult crossed Qinghai and surged toward the Central Plains during the Great Faction War, the unorthodox faction quickly joined them while shouting, "Long live the Cult Leader!"

The Demonic Cult's momentum was overwhelming, but the unorthodox faction also wanted people they saw as their own kind to rule the Murim under Heaven.

For unorthodox martial artists already living in the Central Plains, though, things were different.

If they don't side with the orthodox faction, they'll be hunted down before they can even leave the Central Plains. Those bastards wouldn't dare refuse to join this side.

Jeok Cheongang had once said that with a snort. For the unorthodox martial artists of the Central Plains, it had been the plain truth.

"I heard they were practically eating dumplings through their tears."

"I did not live through that era either, but what I found confirms it."

"What you found?"

"After you left for Sichuan, I stayed in Henan and searched the old archives. There were countless records, including ones about the unorthodox faction."

The Murim Alliance had disbanded when peace returned, but the memories of those who had lived through the Great Faction War—and records of what had happened—remained.

That made sense. In the long history of the Murim, fifty years was *only* half a century.

"What did the records say?"

"What do you think?"

"I can guess. I've heard a few stories."

"I do not know exactly what Great Hero Jeok told you, but most of it was probably true."

"…If that's true, it's pretty damn ridiculous."

From the start of the Great Faction War well into its middle and later stages, the unorthodox martial artists who joined the orthodox faction betrayed them again and again.

Considering what Jeok Cheongang had said about the Murim Alliance's leadership even discussing root-and-branch eradication to remove every unorthodox member from within the orthodox faction, the situation must have been serious.

"But I heard they fought hard later on."

"Unlike at the beginning, neither side's victory was certain. The Hidden Shadow Pavilion, led by Sir Song, the Thousand-Faced Fox, also kept them under close watch. And according to the records, the unorthodox martial artists sensed the leadership's mood changing and began cutting off their own tails."

Not everyone in the orthodox faction was righteous, and not everyone in the unorthodox faction was a monster.

But unlike the orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction possessed the decisiveness and cruelty to cut off its own tail without hesitation.

The instant someone was suspected of being a spy for the Demonic Cult, they slit his throat first and asked questions later.

"In the end, the body survived without its tail. By cooperating with the orthodox faction, it shared in the victory."

The surviving unorthodox forces carried on in the shade of the great tree that was the orthodox faction. Naturally, they could no longer wield the influence they once had.

Their reputation had been bad enough to begin with, and there had been countless instances of them siding with the Demonic Cult.

Most people agreed that if the Murim Alliance's leaders had not acknowledged at least some of their contributions and rights, hardline heroes calling for the extermination of demonic and heterodox elements would have dragged them out and torn them limb from limb.

The contempt directed at the unorthodox faction after the war had endured like an ancient tradition.

That alone was not a serious problem. What came next was.

"We need them to fight alongside us."

"Yes. If they do not join the Murim Alliance, they will side with Dark Heaven."

"I don't like the thought of bringing them into the fold."

"They are not people I would want to trust with my back on a battlefield. There is the precedent, and they must have spent decades resenting how honors and rewards were divided after the war."

"What if we tell them to stay neutral?"

"Suppose the Murim Alliance looks certain to lose. What would you do if you were an unorthodox martial artist, youngest?"

"…Hmm."

Put that bluntly, I had no answer. I smacked my lips before speaking.

"I hate to say it, but I'd side with Dark Heaven."

"Why?"

"If the Murim Alliance wins, they break even. But as you said, the scales are already tilted, and Dark Heaven is on the verge of becoming the master of the Central Plains Murim."

"Exactly."

"And what kind of people are Dark Heaven? They wouldn't leave the unorthodox faction alone. They wouldn't praise them for staying neutral—they'd be furious they hadn't helped when it mattered and kill every last one of them."

"Precisely. That is why the unorthodox faction is a chicken rib."

A chicken rib. That was a good way to put it.

It offered little benefit, but it was too wasteful to throw away. Fighting alongside them felt unpleasant, but if we discarded them, Dark Heaven would pick them up and throw them back at us.

No matter how soft a chicken bone was, it was still a bone. Getting hit by one would hurt quite a bit.

Which meant…

"Henan has already sent them a letter too, hasn't it?"

Jin Wikyung gave a small nod.

"Without a doubt. If we must choose between the two, we need to draw the unorthodox Murim to our side."

For a chicken rib, the unorthodox faction had plenty of meat on it.

Even the dark-path knife-men who wandered the back alleys after sunset belonged to the unorthodox faction. Weren't we at a point where we would be grateful for a single Third Rate knife-man?

More importantly, it was better to keep them close and hold their leash than let them side with Dark Heaven. That would be far too great a loss…

Wait. Dark-path figures?

Something came back to me, and I frowned.

"What is it?"

"No, I just remembered something I heard recently. Regarding the Water God Dragon incident, didn't we accuse the dark-path figures of Hubei Province of being the culprits and wipe them all out?"

"We did."

"…Then the unorthodox faction might be upset. In the end, we accepted the government's proposal and wiped out their own people."

It was a bad look. They might even reject the Murim Alliance's offer of membership over it.

Jin Wikyung, however, looked perfectly calm.

"Two things are wrong with that."

"What?"

"First, the unorthodox Murim has been fractured since the war ended. Those people were rivals, not family. We used this opportunity to uproot the unusually numerous dark-path figures in Hubei. Other unorthodox forces will move into the space they left. For them, it is a new opportunity."

"…!"

"We have given them enough to feed on. They will be satisfied. And when they hear what happened in Hubei, they will understand that it was also a warning."

We had thrown them food and fastened a leash of fear around their necks.

That was how the Murim Alliance tamed the hunting dog known as the unorthodox Murim.

"And second. The government did not make the proposal and receive our acceptance."

Jin Wikyung's voice went dry.

"We did. No—I made the proposal first."

"Oh."

"The government merely accepted it. That distinction matters a great deal."

"…The government agreed that easily?"

"The Provincial Administration Commissioner of Hubei holds a post that can sway an entire province. But people know only that the new commissioner formerly served as an Assistant Provincial Administrator in Shanxi Province. They do not know he is a secret loyal retainer of Prince Shangshan."

A memory of when we had first arrived in Hubei suddenly flashed through my mind.

The hostile looks from the people. And Jin Wikyung questioning the official who had surrounded the ferry landing with government soldiers.

"By the way, do you know a man surnamed Yi whose given name is Hongcheon?"

“H-he was recently appointed Provincial Administration Commissioner. May I ask what your relationship with him is…?”

“I have met him a few times and shared a drink or two. I helped him when he needed it.”

Jin Wikyung looked straight at me. His gaze was gentle, but a cold blade lay behind it.

For an instant, I saw the strategist and politician in him. Then that look melted away.

“Do not worry. Everything will work out.”

Tap, tap.

I could feel the strength in the hand patting my shoulder. I gazed silently at Jin Wikyung, then suddenly spoke.

“What was the Family Head… No, what was Father like?”

The faint smile on Jin Wikyung’s lips vanished.

“No, the mood was so nice. Why bring up that bastard?”

“As you know, I hurt my head back then. I don’t remember him very well.”

“You don’t need to remember him! Just erase him from your mind! I’m your father!”

“…”

I knew he had grievances, but apparently there were more than I had realized.

Jin Wikyung’s fist trembled, as if he were remembering the paperwork hell of those days.

“But why do you ask?”

“No reason. I was just thinking how lucky it is that you took charge of the family after Father disappeared.”

“…Youngest. Please don’t cross the line.”

I shrugged and turned away.

Jin Wikyung asked where I thought I was going when hyung[2389] was talking to me, and whether my affection for him had cooled. Without turning around, I answered,

“You said it’s in a month. I’m going to get ready to leave.”

It was time to leave Hubei behind.

With the people who were by my side, and whom I wanted beside me in the days to come.

“I think I’ve given you enough time by now… Don’t you?”

The mutter that slipped between my lips vanished without a trace beneath the noise around us.

[2389] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

I scratched my chin and looked up at the dizzyingly high cliff.

Chapter 502

“Here you are.”

At the sudden voice behind him, the old man sitting cross-legged with his eyes closed twitched his brow.

“I don’t recall inviting anyone.”

“Not my problem. Still, it’s narrower than I expected. Absurdly so.”

“It has to be narrow. I didn’t set aside any room for uninvited guests.”

“Was it around seven days and nights ago? I’m sure I said something similar to someone…”

For some reason, the old man’s small back shuddered at those words.

Before his uninvited guest could wonder why, a sharp voice cut through the cave.

“Leave. You’re disturbing my meditation.”

“Continue your meditation. I’ll personally stand guard for you.”

The old man—Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King—opened his eyes.

The darkness gave way to damp cave walls mottled with moss. A testy voice escaped between his tightly pressed lips.

“You expect this old man to let the Slaughter Saint stand guard over him? What a ridiculous joke.”

“I thought you could trust me with an old man’s life, if not your precious Disciple’s. Was I mistaken?”

“…!”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyelids trembled. Then—

Shuuk.

Still sitting cross-legged, his small figure rose into the air, turned slowly, and landed facing the cave entrance.

Jeok Cheongang silently stared at the man blocking the narrow cave entrance before asking, “How did you know I was here?”

Mungyeong answered dryly. “When I came up, a great tiger walked over and rubbed its head against me. It had clearly done that before.”

“I left no tracks.”

“Finding people used to be my work.”

“So you can pretend to be a medical apprentice all you like, but you’re still an assassin?”

“There are things you can’t forget, however hard you try. That’s all. There are eyes everywhere, and nothing but river around us. You didn’t have many places to go.”

A fine sword kept its edge no matter how many years passed.

More than forty years had passed, and the blade called the Slaughter Saint was as sharp as ever. No—his instincts as an assassin might have dulled, but his realm as a martial artist had risen higher.

"…Perhaps I should have found somewhere harder to reach."

"It would have taken me a little longer."

Assassins were masters of both killing and pursuit.

Reading the confidence in Mungyeong's calm expression, Jeok Cheongang muttered, "Damn it. What an irritating assassin."

"I can hear you."

"I meant you to."

"Cursing me out of nowhere. What a foul-tempered host."

"Are you any better, barging in on someone's secluded meditation without warning?"

"The Fire King, in secluded meditation."

Mungyeong's flat voice echoed through the cave.

He looked around. The place was so cramped and damp that calling it a cave seemed generous. Apart from the old man sitting cross-legged, it held nothing at all.

Which made the signs on that one man impossible to miss.

Jeok Cheongang. He's…

Cracked lips. Knobby bones standing out beneath his skin. Mungyeong's gaze darkened as he took in Jeok Cheongang's condition.

From his gaunt appearance, he clearly hadn't eaten a thing in seven days and nights—not even taken a drop of water. Even for a Supreme Peak master, that would take a toll.

"You're doing something foolish."

Jeok Cheongang understood what Mungyeong meant. A fierce light shone from his sunken eyes.

"I'll give you your own words back. Not your problem."

"What about the fasting pills?"

"I'm not eating them. They taste like shit."

"…Did you take after him in that, too?"

"What?"

"Nothing."

He'd said something pointless. Almost as pointless as Jeok Cheongang's flimsy claim that he refused the fasting pills because they tasted bad.

Mungyeong shook his head. "As a medical apprentice, I'm telling you this is a poor choice."

"And as this old man, I'm telling you to mind your own business."

“You’re even more stubborn than I expected.”

“And you’re more meddlesome than I expected. Since when did you care so much about other people’s business?”

“That…”

Mungyeong fell silent. He wanted to argue, but nothing came to mind. That was as good as admitting Jeok Cheongang had a point.

Maybe he isn’t entirely wrong.

He hadn’t been like this when he left Sichuan. Somewhere along the way, though, he had begun to change, little by little.

To fool the people watching him, he had played an innocent young medical apprentice who smiled and talked freely. But when he was alone with Jeok Cheongang or Jin Taekyung, he had no reason to keep up an act that didn’t suit him.

So why did he feel so talkative today?

No. Perhaps it wasn’t only today.

Why?

He remembered accepting Jeok Cheongang’s absurd proposal seven days and nights ago. He remembered, too, the indescribable bitterness on the old man’s face as he spoke.

Mungyeong opened his mouth.

“Why don’t you ask?”

“Ask what?”

“About Jin Taekyung.”

“…!”

Now it was Jeok Cheongang’s turn to fall silent.

He had tried so hard to avoid that name. He had hoped Mungyeong would let it pass unspoken. Hearing it was enough to stir the feelings he had forced down.

“That boy… Is he doing well?”

“He’s keeping up, more or less. Not bad.”

Jeok Cheongang couldn’t hold back a hollow laugh.

“Why are you laughing?”

“Because I know that’s nonsense. ‘More or less’? That’s the funniest thing I’ve heard in a while.”

“…”

“Never mind me. Tell me what you really think.”

Mungyeong studied him. “His progress is astonishingly fast. Enough to surprise even me.”

“I said to tell me what you really think.”

“That *is* what I think.”

“Half of it. You left out the part where you want him for yourself.”

“…”

“Yes. It was always like that.”

A faint smile touched Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

From the day he first met Jin Taekyung, every day had brought a new surprise. With a Heaven-given physique and extraordinary martial talent, Taekyung was someone any Supreme Peak master who had established martial arts of his own would want as a Disciple.

Jeok Cheongang was no exception.

“When I first got to know Taekyung, a thought struck me. If I passed the Fire Gate Clan’s martial arts on to this boy, perhaps he might see the very limits of martial arts.”

The Fire Gate Clan needed someone to carry on a lineage hundreds of years old, and Jin Taekyung fit that need better than anyone else.

That was how it had started.

“At first, I was simply amazed. Then I felt regret. I didn’t have much time left.”

Alone, he had defeated a thousand Demonic Cult martial artists and brought countless fiends to their knees. By the strength of his own martial arts, he had turned the tide of battle and led the charge toward victory in the Great Faction War.

Yet the Supreme Peak master revered throughout Murim as the Fire King had another, truer enemy.

“It was long ago that the Heart Demon[2390] came for me.”

The wound left by his first Disciple ran deep. It ate away at the body and mind of the Master left alone. Little by little, slowly, without ever stopping.

“It was strange. Everything else kept moving forward, while I alone was walking backward.”

The years flew like an arrow. By the time it struck its target, more than thirty had passed.

Jeok Cheongang had let them flow downriver without gaining the slightest enlightenment. Then, one day, he came face-to-face with something he could scarcely believe.

“It was a clear blue day. I was enjoying the cool breeze, and then I came to my senses among a crowd of people. Half a day had passed, and I knew nothing of it. Heh.”

He had laughed like that on the day the infirmities of old age first came upon him.

He had laughed neither from happiness nor from resignation. He simply had not known what else to do.

[2390] *Simma*, literally “heart demon,” refers to inner turmoil that impedes a martial artist’s cultivation.

It was only when that first lost half-day became two full days that Jeok Cheongang knew what he had to do.

“I left Mount Jiuhua to kill one person.”

And returned with one person.

“He was my first Disciple. I had to deal with him myself before it was too late.”

After meeting Jin Taekyung, though, Jeok Cheongang had realized that wasn’t the only thing he had left too late.

“Slaughter Saint. May I ask you for another favor?”

His gaze and tone had changed. Both were gentler than Mungyeong had ever known them.

“If I am not here, become that boy’s dependable shelter. Become his new Master.”

A deep furrow formed on Mungyeong’s smooth forehead. He stared at Jeok Cheongang through narrowed eyes.

“Do you mean that?”

“More than anything I have ever said.”

“Why?”

“Just as I said. I have no time left.”

“What is this…”

A new Master, out of nowhere? No time left?

Mungyeong knew Jeok Cheongang’s condition, but he couldn’t make sense of this. His innate qi, the source of everything, had been disrupted. He would gradually lose his strength, but that should have taken years.

This was too soon.

“I ask this of you.”

“…!”

Jeok Cheongang bowed his head. The Fire King himself.

Mungyeong was bewildered by a sight no one else in Murim had ever witnessed.

“Why? Seven days and nights ago, you were clearly…”

Mungyeong’s voice cut off abruptly. He swallowed the rest of his words and silently stared at the ripples stirring in Jeok Cheongang’s eyes.

A thought struck him in the suffocating silence.

So that’s it. That’s what happened.

If he was right, it explained everything: Jeok Cheongang’s excessive worry, his disappearance from Jin Taekyung and the others, and his strange reactions throughout their conversation.

“It wasn’t seven days and nights ago, was it?”

“No. It was definitely seven days and nights ago.”

Jeok Cheongang smiled bitterly.

“But to me, those seven days and nights were only five days.”

Time flowed equally for everyone. Not everyone experienced it equally.

The first uninvited guest, arriving a step ahead of Mungyeong, had been the infirmities of old age. They had stolen two days from Jeok Cheongang and fled.

“…When did it start?”

“Sichuan.”

“Sichuan? But when I took your pulse, you were clearly…”

“The symptoms appeared immediately after I left Sichuan. After that, I did my best to avoid you.”

Why had he hidden it? Why?

The question died on Mungyeong’s tongue. He already knew.

How small a person felt when they first realized they had grown old. How frightening it was to realize their mind had begun to come and go with the infirmities of old age.

Seeing Mungyeong fall silent, Jeok Cheongang gave a rueful smile.

“Even if I’d come to tell you, nothing would have changed. I know my own body. You may be the Divine Physician, with medical skill that reaches Heaven, but even you can’t stop innate qi once it starts leaking away.”

“…”

“At first, my memory grew hazy. Then one day, moments were missing from my day. I knew what it meant because I’d been through it before.”

Those moments became the time it took to drink a cup of tea. That became fifteen minutes. Now it was two days.

Jeok Cheongang had searched desperately for a way to stop it, to no avail.

“Acquired qi from elixirs can’t restore a balance that’s already been broken. That left me one choice.”

“…Enlightenment.”

“Yes. Enlightenment.”

“So that’s why you began this secluded meditation.”

“I wanted to live as the Fire King Jeok Cheongang. Not as an old man with infirmities who cannot even remember his own name, but as the current Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan and someone’s Master.”

His desolate voice echoed through the cave. Drops gathered on the damp ceiling and fell, like an old man’s tears.

Chapter 503

A curse laid upon him by time.

The infirmities of old age.

Mungyeong silently rolled the words over his tongue. They left a dry, bitter taste, though he never spoke them aloud. Jeok Cheongang's voice was just as bitter.

"I intend to leave. I'll rest my body and mind at Mount Jiuhua."

"…!"

"If anyone understands why, it's you. Please don't try to stop me."

Just as Jeok Cheongang said, Mungyeong knew exactly why he wanted to leave.

He's afraid of becoming a burden.

The infirmities of old age would come for Jeok Cheongang again and again. If his mind went hazy at a crucial moment, everyone beside him would be in danger.

His enemies feared the Fire King Jeok Cheongang, not an old man who couldn't remember his own name or where he lived.

More precisely, he's afraid his Disciple will be in danger.

Everyone had something precious they could not afford to lose.

To a beggar begging in the marketplace, a half-crushed dumpling was his life. To an emperor who commanded all the civil and military officials, the jade seal symbolizing his authority and power was more precious than a thousand or ten thousand subjects.

Jin Taekyung was that precious to Jeok Cheongang.

Someone he would trade his life for. Someone he could not lose, no matter what.

"You're awfully fond of your Disciple."

"My Disciple. Yes, my Disciple."

"If you're going to spout the same nonsense you did last time, spare me."

Jeok Cheongang gave a bitter smile at Mungyeong's hard tone.

"No, you're right. He's this old man's one and only Disciple."

"So you think you're a burden to him? You're so afraid of that you'd leave him of your own accord?"

"It's the only choice. I'm doing it for the boy."

"There are other choices. The imugi's[2391] inner core you obtained, for one."

"You know as well as I do that acquired qi from elixirs can't cure this. Besides…"

Jeok Cheongang looked down at his wrinkled hands and muttered,

"This old man has grown too old. Even if the imugi's[2392] inner core could help, I can't use it on an old man like me on the slim chance that it might work."

[2391] An **imugi** is a legendary Korean serpent often associated with dragons.

[2392] An **imugi** is a legendary Korean serpent often associated with dragons.

"…!"

"Patch the bottom of an old boat, and water will still leak through somewhere else in the hull. But the boy—my Disciple—is different."

Light entered his downcast eyes. Joy and hope. Mungyeong could see everything Jeok Cheongang felt for his Disciple in them.

"I have no choice. Please grant this old man's request, so I can leave with peace of mind."

"…You have no choice. Is that what you're saying?"

"Will you look after the boy for me again?"

Mungyeong stared at him for a moment, then said, "Take a boat east from Zhejiang and you'll come to a small island country."

"An island country?"

"You must have heard the name. The Wa Kingdom.[2393]"

"…?"

"You haven't?"

Jeok Cheongang blinked at the sudden question.

"Of course I have. Wa pirates have been coming here to raid us for ages."

"Have you ever seen one?"

"No, but I hear they're strange-looking fellows. They carry swords as long as their own bodies, shave half their foreheads back, and walk around wearing rags like undergarments."

"Whoever told you got it right."

"But why bring this up all of a—"

"A long time ago," Mungyeong cut in, "I fought the finest ninja in the Wa Kingdom."

Jeok Cheongang had heard of ninjas. They were much like the assassins of the Central Plains: not especially skilled in martial arts, but excellent at concealment techniques and at using hidden weapons such as throwing blades.

"There's no need to ask how it turned out. So are you boasting that you killed the finest ninja in the Wa Kingdom?"

"I didn't kill him. My objective was to capture him alive."

A captured target had two choices: speak after a little pain, or speak after terrible pain.

No matter which one he chose, death waited at the end. In the end, the difference was only how painfully he died.

"He chose the latter."

[2393] **Wa** (倭) was a historical name used in China and Korea for Japan.

As befitted the Wa Kingdom's finest ninja, he held out for quite some time. Unfortunately for him, Salcheonmun—the sect Mungyeong belonged to then—was unquestionably the finest assassin sect in the Central Plains.

They used every torture method they knew. Amid pain worse than death, the ninja was forced to spit out every piece of information he possessed. Not just information, but every memory buried in his mind.

"That was when I heard about a custom in the Wa Kingdom."

"A custom?"

"Did you know some people there abandon their elderly parents in the mountains?"

"…I can't say I'm surprised, but those bastards ought to make heaven and earth furious."

"I was told it was to have fewer mouths to feed. They leave their parents there without caring whether they starve or get torn apart by wild animals. They're too old to work anymore."

Abandoning the parents who had raised them simply because they had grown old—if it was true, those people were vicious beyond belief.

Commoners sometimes broke even the bonds between parent and child during terrible disasters. But for it to be a custom was another matter entirely.

Mungyeong continued flatly. "The ninja I captured said he'd abandoned his mother the same way. What do you think she said to her son as he left her deep in the mountains?"

"You fucking bastard."

"…"

"You motherless bastard."

Seeing Mungyeong's face harden until it was stiffer than Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, Jeok Cheongang continued with a laugh in his voice.

"That boy Taekyung would answer like that. But she was different. A mother doesn't stop caring for her child so easily, even when he abandons her. So what did she say?"

"She told him to go slowly. It might get dark and he could fall, so he shouldn't hurry. He should watch his step on the mountain path."

Jeok Cheongang could understand what that mother had felt. His decision to leave was rooted in something similar.

He wasn't being abandoned like the mother in Mungyeong's story, but he, too, wanted to go before he became a burden to someone precious.

And if the Slaughter Saint is telling this old man such a story…

Relief and bitterness mingled in his eyes as he looked at Mungyeong.

"May I take that to mean you'll grant my request?"

Mungyeong always called himself a medical apprentice. Jeok Cheongang thought he had brought up a past he hated remembering to compare him to the ninja's mother—and, in doing so, tacitly accept his proposal.

Then Mungyeong shook his head.

"What does that mean?"

"I thought shaking one's head meant the same thing everywhere, in every age. Is it different in the Fire Gate Clan?"

"Then why tell me that story…?"

"I forgot to tell you the ending. The ninja's mother lived out her natural lifespan and was buried in a sunny spot. Her last words brought her unfilial son to his senses, and he went back and brought her home."

"…!"

At that moment, Jeok Cheongang's body abruptly froze.

At last he understood what Mungyeong had been telling him. How foolish the thought that had consumed him was.

Even as she was being abandoned, the ninja's mother worried about her son. And I was going to leave that boy of my own accord.

Jeok Cheongang hadn't wanted to burden Jin Taekyung, his one and only Disciple. That was all.

But this wasn't a selfless act for his Disciple's sake. It was the stubborn delusion of a proud old man thinking only of himself.

When had it been? He remembered a conversation he had shared with Jin Taekyung one ordinary day at Mount Jiuhua, when they had lain side by side on a broad rock.

You're holding up better than I expected. Is your body made of iron?

I'm Iron Man.

For spouting nonsense, I'm adding two hundred geun[2394] of iron balls.

…Ah.

Ha! I'm joking. Strange. I've grown so used to your nonsense that it doesn't even annoy me anymore.

It's fine. Put the iron balls on me later.

Must you make me say it twice? I said I was joking.

I'm serious.

Hmm?

There'll be plenty of people stronger than me once we leave. I don't want to be treated like a burden later on for no reason. They say the iron balls weigh less if you put them on early, so just add them.

Look at you. Add two hundred geun, and you think you'll never be a burden?

[2394] **Wa** (倭) was a historical name used in China and Korea for Japan.

No, but I should at least try as hard as I can. That way, if I collapse someday, you'll pick me up, won't you, Old Master?

Now you're proudly calling yourself a burden. Fine. If this old man does that, what will you do for me?

If you ever collapse, Old Master, I'll carry you on my back.

Hah. You think this old man will collapse?

If you get tired, I could at least support you, couldn't I? So tell me when it gets hard.

…I hear you're an arrogant, impertinent brat. Five hundred geun of iron balls added.

Are you insane, human?

It had been an ordinary conversation on an unremarkable day.

Yet Jeok Cheongang had often thought back to it. How he'd barked at the boy, turned away, and let out a quiet laugh. How he'd added more iron balls, then hidden nearby to watch, worried the boy might hurt himself.

Even now, at this very moment, Jin Taekyung's voice from that day echoed in Jeok Cheongang's ears like a distant refrain.

If you ever collapse, Old Master, I'll carry you on my back.

He had always pictured himself in front, Taekyung behind him. All the more reason he could never collapse.

If you get tired, I could at least support you, couldn't I?

He hadn't wanted Taekyung to see him stagger, either. Like every father, he wanted to be invincible, at least to him.

It had been the same on the day he charged forward ready to die.

Dance of the Fire God and Demon… That's a pretty cool name.

Y-you bastard, how did you—

You should've crushed his head. Made sure of it.

Cough!

Old Master!

But Jeok Cheongang wasn't invincible.

Only after waking from his long sleep did he learn what his Disciple had endured with his fallen, pitiful Master on his back. How many times Taekyung had risked his precious life and fought through desperate odds.

So Jeok Cheongang had resolved never to collapse again. Never to become a burden that put his Disciple in danger.

But he had been wrong.

We were walking side by side. Following the same path, from the beginning until now. Always together.

One thought filled his mind.

Then dark, damp memories surged from the depths of his past and clouded his vision.

Fwoosh!

Countless memories and emotions stretched back to a beggar boy struggling to pick up a single dumpling.

Rage and despair. Sorrow and guilt. They crashed over Jeok Cheongang like waves and gripped his entire body.

But why did he feel no pain?

The tightness in his chest that always came when he recalled the past was gone. So was the headache that felt as if it would split his skull.

What is this?

For the first time in a very long while, he felt at peace. A cool breeze brushed against him from somewhere, carrying voices with it.

Oh, that feels good.

Ahem. This is the finest auspicious site on Mount Jiuhua, personally selected by this old man.

"This rock is practically a Jangsu stone bed.[2395] Five stars."

Ahem!

Warmth. Brilliant light seeped in.

The darkness that had crouched deep in Jeok Cheongang's heart for decades was slowly scattering.

The Heart Demon.

That was the name of the darkness he carried within himself, the chain that had bound him. And all it took to drive it away was a cool breeze on a clear day at Mount Jiuhua, and someone's voice.

Fwoosh!

Old Master.

Light swallowed the darkness. Swallowed the Heart Demon. Though his eyes were closed, everything around him shone so brightly it dazzled him.

A faint smile touched Jeok Cheongang's wrinkled lips.

Yes.

His snow-white hair stirred in a breeze that had blown from somewhere. It was neither an illusion nor a mistake.

Fwoooosh!

At last, the giant had broken his chains and risen to his feet. Wind poured from the Fire King Jeok Cheongang and swept out in every direction.

[2395] **Jangsu** is a Korean stone-bed brand; Taekyung compares the rock to one of its beds and gives it a five-star rating.

Chapter 504

Enlightenment comes when you least expect it.

When you have forgotten everything around you in a state of selflessness. When death is right before your eyes. Or when you finally cast off the chains that have bound your body and mind for decades.

That was how enlightenment came.

Fwooooooosh!

A wind of qi surged from one man and swept in every direction.

The cave interior was dark, deprived of even a ray of light, but it was now brightly illuminated by a halo of light.

Mungyeong watched the strange sight in silence. Then the boy spoke softly.

“Have you finally escaped your Heart Demon[2396]?”

He hadn’t set out to bring this about. He had only wanted Jeok Cheongang to know that he wasn’t alone. That he didn’t have to isolate himself and carry every worry and burden on his own.

The result had gone beyond anything Mungyeong expected.

The Supreme Peak master known as the Fire King had broken the chains that had bound him for so many years and was stepping into a new realm.

“Seems I wasn’t meddling for nothing after all.”

Complex emotions mingled in Mungyeong’s eyes as he murmured to himself.

He didn’t know why he had sought out Jeok Cheongang or helped a man he barely knew.

No—even if he did know, he would have pretended otherwise. That was the kind of person he was. It was how he had lived his entire life.

But…

It doesn’t feel so bad.

Mungyeong didn’t realize that a faint smile had crossed his lips.

Nor did he know that the same thing had happened once before, a few days ago.

The smile had come and gone too quickly for him to notice. He slowly turned and stepped out of the cramped cave into the world beyond.

Whoosh.

As if on cue, a breeze from outside blew past, stirring his hair and tickling his nose.

Mungyeong gazed silently at the thick grass and flowers around the cave, then at the wild animals that had gathered there. At last, he spoke.

[2396] A Heart Demon is an inner obsession or psychological obstacle that can hinder a martial artist’s progress.

“Someone will have to stand guard. If those animals wander into the cave without knowing any better, all the enlightenment he worked so hard to attain will go to waste.”

Squeak?

A fawn grazing beside its sleeping mother pricked up its ears.

Under the animals’ wary, curious gazes, Mungyeong looked up at the blue sky.

“It’s a beautiful day. I can’t stay cooped up in a cave in weather like this.”

Step.

Muttering as if to himself, Mungyeong began to walk, neither quickly nor slowly.

The wind blew once more, as though seeing him off while he left the cave behind and disappeared.

Whoosh.

A clear sky without a single cloud. A cool breeze. Wild animals lying together among the grass and flowers, enjoying the sunlight.

And…

Someone lingering outside, unable to bring himself to go in.

Master and Disciple alike.

No matter how he looked at it, those two were alike.

Two butterflies fluttered down and landed on Mungyeong’s shoulder as he smiled without a sound.

It was truly a beautiful day.

The fawn had only recently been born, and it was curious about everything.

It bounded after butterflies and stuck its black nose into the thick grass and flowers to sniff them.

As always, it soon lost interest and wandered off in search of something else to do.

Squeak?

This time was different.

The cave’s pitch-black entrance drew it in, while its mother slept, worn out from caring for it.

Most importantly, the strange two-legged animal it had never seen before had disappeared into the distance.

Squeak.

What’s in there? I want to go inside.

Squeak!

All right. Let’s go!

But the fawn's firm resolve lasted only as long as it took to nibble a few mouthfuls of grass.

Step.

Someone approached, and a shadow fell over its round head.

The fawn startled and backed away. A large figure appeared in its black eyes.

"Not right now. We'll go in later."

The stranger stroked the frightened fawn's head, then stared at the pitch-black cave.

The stranger's gaze was so profoundly somber that the fawn, which had instinctively been about to wake its mother, swallowed its cry.

Squeeeeak.

"That's right. Good. Now go back to your mother."

The figure watched the fawn tilt its head and approach its sleeping mother, then straightened from his bent posture.

His steps toward the cave were steady. The wind blurred his voice.

"Now… I should go, too."

The path to the cave was long.

A year and several months had passed since the old man and the young man first met. After taking the long way around, they could finally meet again.

Not one in front and the other behind, but side by side, shoulder to shoulder.

"When the hell is Jin Taekyung coming?"

At Gung Gibang's irritated complaint, Hyuk Mujin clicked his tongue.

"Tsk, tsk. With a temper that impatient, how are you ever going to beg? Try waiting patiently for once."

"Listen to the way that Hyuk bastard talks. Beggars aren't allowed to be impatient?"

"You need patience if you want someone to give you even one iron coin."

"Was it the Hyuk Family Textile Shop? Want me to send a hundred thousand Beggars' Sect disciples over to take a shit there, one by one?"

"…Let's leave family out of this."

"Then watch your mouth. My boys might not have money, but you think they don't have shit?"

Hyuk Mujin looked at him in disgust.

"You're driving me crazy. I just ate, so why the hell are you talking about shit? We have to board the ship soon, too."

"So before the Hyuk Family Textile Shop gets covered in shit—"

“Ah, I said stop! Hearing about food after talking about eating shit is making my stomach turn!”

“…?”

“…?”

As the two men tilted their heads, sensing something was wrong, Jin Wikyung addressed someone nearby.

“Tell me, are you certain he’ll be here soon?”

Mungyeong, the young medical apprentice known as the Divine Physician’s Disciple, bowed politely.

“Yes. Young Master Jin said so himself.”

“We need to leave before sunset…”

Jin Wikyung murmured as he gazed at the sky slowly turning red.

The ceremony declaring the new Murim Alliance in Henan was only about a month away. They had to set out now and keep up a good pace if they were to arrive on time, allowing for anything that might happen along the way.

No. I should be grateful Great Hero Jeok is coming with us at all.

Rumors had been swirling about Jeok Cheongang, who had shut himself away for seven days and nights.

Some said, hopefully, that he had finally found a clue to enlightenment. Others made the impious suggestion that something might be wrong with his health. Still others insisted he simply had no particular reason to show himself.

Jin Wikyung didn’t know which of the three was true, but he had certainly worried in private.

I was afraid he might refuse to join the Murim Alliance… It seems my youngest managed to persuade him.

Most martial artists of the orthodox faction had forgotten it, but the Fire King Jeok Cheongang had never belonged to the orthodox, unorthodox, or Demonic factions. He stood between the orthodox and unorthodox factions.

That independence was the foundation of the Fire Gate Clan, which had preserved its lineage through one-person succession for hundreds of years. Each Sect Leader had defended its position outside every faction with overwhelming martial might.

Especially since it was Great Hero Jeok.

Even a child with a runny nose knew that the Fire King Jeok Cheongang had helped the orthodox faction and led it to victory in the Great Faction War.

But few people knew that this Supreme Peak master from two generations ago had been deeply disappointed by the orthodox faction both during and after the war.

“Come to think of it, I’m reminded of something my grandfather once said about Senior Jeok.”

Zhuge Feng had come out to see them off. At his words, Jin Wikyung's ear twitched.

"About Great Hero Jeok?"

"Yes."

"I've heard the previous Family Head was wise and had remarkable insight. May I ask what he said?"

"Well, I heard it in the Family Head's hall when I was thirteen."

"I see. And what did he say…?"

"I remember it clearly. My grandfather was talking about the Great Faction War. Ah, have you heard how the members of our family played a major role in the great battle in Sichuan?"

Crack.

Zhuge Feng, who had been leisurely fanning himself, suddenly stopped.

He glanced back and forth between Jin Wikyung's tightly clenched fist and his flushed face, then slowly lowered the fan.

Jin Wikyung's martial arts were in no way inferior, but even his appearance alone made him little different from a human weapon.

Besides, with the priceless Water God Dragon's corpse in his hands, was he not the one holding all the cards?

Zhuge Feng discreetly gauged the mood, cleared his throat, and continued.

"Ahem. In any case, I asked him first. I asked when he thought the tide had first begun to turn in favor of the orthodox faction."

Jin Wikyung's voice was low and level.

"Was it because the Zhuge Clan played such an important role in the great battle in Sichuan?"

"No! That wasn't it! It really wasn't!"

"That's a relief. Please continue."

Zhuge Feng began speaking while glancing sideways at the clenched fist.

"It was the first and last time I ever saw my grandfather think so long over a question. Can you guess what he finally said, Lesser Family Head?"

"You said it was connected to Great Hero Jeok… Perhaps it was the great battle in Shaanxi. I've heard the other Seniors distinguished themselves there, but Great Hero Jeok's achievements were truly astounding."

The battle in Shaanxi that Jin Wikyung had mentioned was one of the particularly brilliant victories among the countless battles of the blood-soaked Great Faction War.

Jin Wikyung had given his answer some thought, but Zhuge Feng let out a quiet laugh and shook his head.

"Wrong."

“Then what was it?”

“Anhui.”

“Anhui… You mean that?”

“That’s right. No one expected the Demonic Cult’s elite Black Wind Corps—a thousand men marching across Anhui—to be wiped out by one man. Not even my grandfather.”

Jin Wikyung nodded.

On the day Mount Jiuhua was engulfed in flames, an unknown old man living in obscurity became known as the Fire King, while the Demonic Cult lost an elite strike force that had accumulated countless achievements since the beginning of the Great Faction War.

“That makes sense. It was when Great Hero Jeok first emerged into the world.”

“But if not for my wise and perceptive grandfather’s judgment, not only would the Black Wind Corps not have been annihilated, Senior Jeok would never have gained the title of Fire King.”

“What do you mean…?”

Zhuge Feng looked around, then lowered his voice as much as possible.

“At the time, every road through Anhui was open to the Black Wind Corps. They had no reason to pass through Mount Jiuhua.”

“Wait. Then do you mean…?”

“My grandfather never forgot anything he had seen once. This was no different. He remembered a record about a one-person sect in our family’s archives, one describing events from more than a hundred years ago.”

“…!”

“Heh heh. It was a bold gamble, but it worked. A stratagem to put even Zhuge Wuhou[2397] to shame, wouldn’t you say?”

As Zhuge Feng casually put his own clan’s ancestor to shame, a deep voice reached his ear.

“So that’s what happened.”

“…Huh?”

Zhuge Feng turned in bewilderment and saw him.

“Zhuge Clan, assemble.”

A middle-aged man was approaching from far beyond the distance his voice should have carried.

And walking beside him, shoulder to shoulder, was a young man.

[2397] Zhuge Wuhou is an honorific title for Zhuge Liang, a renowned strategist of China’s Three Kingdoms period.

Chapter 505

Returned to Youth was the realm every martial artist in Murim dreamed of reaching.

When immense internal energy combined with enlightenment, the body was remade, restoring the youth it had once possessed.

But if Returned to Youth were easy, countless martial artists wouldn't have died dreaming of it. It was impossible without Heaven's help. And walking beside me now was a man who, after long years of painstaking effort, had finally received that stroke of heavenly luck.

"Zhuge Clan, assemble."

Blazing red hair streamed in the wind. A solid frame of taut muscle stood nearly seven feet tall, and his voice had the weight of an iron club.

…I really can't get used to this.

Could a person change *that* much? The longer I looked, the stranger I felt.

The Fire King Jeok Cheongang I knew had been a short, impossibly old man who stood barely five feet tall. He had looked like he could hardly grow any older—not like a fit middle-aged man who appeared to be in his mid-to-late forties.

Jeok Cheongang noticed me staring. He stopped walking and muttered under his breath.

"Why? Why are you looking at me again?"

"I mean, come on. How did this happen? How old were you when you looked like this?"

"I was probably not yet sixty. My hair was never red, though. Not once."

"How did you get so much shorter as you aged? I know people shrink, but… did someone cut off your legs when you were around eighty?"

"No one cut off mine. I could cut off the legs of a certain bastard who's been running his mouth since earlier, though."

Jeok Cheongang glared at me, then smacked his lips.

"Anyway, stop looking at me like that. Even this old man isn't used to it yet."

"If you're not used to it yourself—wait. It feels weird calling you Old Master now."

"Then what will you call me?"

"Mister?"

"…"

"Hey, Mr. Jeok?"

"…Do you want to fucking die?"

What a relief. That murderous tone was definitely Jeok Cheongang's.

As I felt oddly reassured, familiar faces drew near and looked between us in confusion.

"Huh?"

"Captain, who's that beside you?"

A perfectly normal reaction. Mungyeong and the few others who knew what had happened reacted differently.

"M-my youngest."

"B-Benefactor. Is that…?"

Jin Wikyung and Cheongpung caught on quickly. Jin Wikyung always kept his composure and read the situation, while Cheongpung was the strongest Supreme Peak master here after Mungyeong. It wasn't surprising that they'd guessed.

Then there was Zhuge Feng. He fixed me with a grave look.

"Red hair and a red beard. According to the reports I received, no martial artist with such distinctive features has come through here. More importantly, he's walking right beside you, which suggests you're quite close. But you don't have any friends, do you?"

"…That pisses me off, but you're not wrong. So?"

"Thus, my brilliant mind leads me to suspect that the martial artist beside you might be Senior Jeok, Returned to Youth… Ha ha. What do you think? Fairly plausible nonsense, isn't it?"

"That's right."

"No, it isn't. It's nonsense."

"What do you mean, no? I'm telling you it's true."

"Please tell me it's nonsense. I beg you."

"It's true."

That answer didn't come from me. Jeok Cheongang stepped forward with that short, weighty declaration, and the air around us stirred.

"Gasp!"

"R-Returned to Youth?"

"Then that man really is…!"

There was a truckload of Wudang and Zhuge Clan martial artists stationed around the makeshift wharf to guard and investigate the area. Ship-Fire Boy[2398] Mu Song and the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold were there too, ready to take us out.

As everyone stared wide-eyed, Zhuge Feng's gaze wavered.

Why is the Fire King here…?

It was written all over his face. Amid the uproar, he looked silently at Jeok Cheongang, then respectfully cupped his hands.

"Senior, it is good to see you. I was terribly worried something might have happened to you…"

[2398] Mu Song's sobriquet refers literally to a boy who lights fires aboard a ship.

“I’d wondered why those Demonic Cult bastards came to Mount Jiuhua when they had so many other roads to take. Now I know.”

Zhuge Feng gave an awkward laugh at the razor edge in Jeok Cheongang’s voice.

“I’m afraid I don’t know what you mean.”

“Pretend you don’t know one more time, and you won’t like what happens.”

“…May I ask how much you heard?”

“From ‘if not for my wise and perceptive grandfather’s judgment.‘”

“Ah. You heard all of it.”

“I did.”

“If I said everything I told them was a misunderstanding…”

“I’d burn the Zhuge Clan to the ground.”

“Ah…”

“No wonder those goddamn Demonic Cult bastards came this way with all those other roads available.”

Jeok Cheongang clenched his fist, his eyes cold. Even when he’d looked like he might drop dead any day, that look had made everyone back down. Now that he’d Returned to Youth, the force of his aura was enough to make knees buckle.

“I woke from a nap to find Mount Jiuhua on fire. What do you think of that?”

“I don’t think it was good.”

“And?”

Zhuge Feng swallowed hard.

“I imagine you were displeased.”

“It was fucking awful. If this old man hadn’t hurried over, even my home would’ve burned to ash.”

“Your home survived, then. Thank goodness.”

“Everything but my home burned. My heart, too.”

“Ah…”

“Now, I’ll give you two choices.”

Jeok Cheongang raised a finger.

“First, I round up every bastard named Zhuge, line them up five abreast, and slap them all across the face.”

That would be quite a sight.

Before I’d finished the thought, Zhuge Feng answered without taking a breath.

“I accept the second proposal.”

“Do you even know what it is?”

“Whatever it is, I choose the second.”

I would’ve picked number two myself.

To a martial artist, pride was nearly as important as life itself. If word spread that the entire Zhuge Clan had been slapped in a line by the Fire King Jeok Cheongang, the clan would have to take down its sign from that very day onward. Even a member of the Five Great Families like the Zhuge Clan would be no exception.

Zhuge Feng had chosen wisely. Still, he couldn't quite hide his unease.

"What is the second proposal?"

Jeok Cheongang stroked his short red beard. He slowly looked over everyone present, me included, then spoke.

"Do better from now on."

"Senior, forgive me, but what exactly—"

"The war has already begun. Do as well as the Zhuge Clan did in the Great Faction War—no, better. Like your grandfather."

"…!"

"Well, your grandfather didn't conspire with the Demonic Cult and tell them to burn Mount Jiuhua. And it's absurd to stay angry at a man who's dead and buried. I can't exactly go to his grave and turn it over again."

Jeok Cheongang looked at me.

"Besides, if those Demonic Cult bastards hadn't set Mount Jiuhua on fire that day, another bond would never have formed… Why are you making that face?"

I hurriedly composed my expression before answering.

"This is my normal face."

"…I have an idea what you're thinking, but I'll let it pass."

If I admitted I'd expected him to visit the former Family Head's grave and piss on it, Jeok Cheongang would try to kill me. Judging by everyone else's faces, I wasn't the only one who'd thought it.

Still, he's giving it this much thought. I'm a little touched.

As Jeok Cheongang had said, if he had remained a reclusive master in Mount Jiuhua, we would never have ended up working together. We would have lived in our separate worlds, never knowing the other existed.

But the pendulum of fate had led me to the Murim and connected me with Jeok Cheongang.

And whether this was fate as well or not, we had to move toward our next destination once more.

Henan.

The moment that word filled my mind, Mungyeong spoke up. He'd been standing apart all this time, his expression unreadable.

"The sun is about to set."

The western mountains were already red. Jeok Cheongang, whose hair was redder still, grinned at me.

"Come. Let's go."

"Yes."

Right. Let's go.

To Henan. To the New Murim Alliance.

"So they've all left?"

The first to speak was an old Daoist with a refined face. His skin was as taut as a young man's, without a single age spot, and the long hem of his robe was dazzling white.

The Daoist who had brought him the news was old too, but his many-times-patched clothes spoke to his unassuming nature.

Clack.

Perfected Being[2399] Hyeongong set down his teacup.

"Yes, Sect Leader Senior Brother."

The two boys who had studied under the same master since childhood were now respected Perfected Beings[2400] and pillars of Wudang.

Hyeongong, who had cared for little besides martial arts, had reached Supreme Peak and made a name for himself. His Senior Brother, seven years his elder, had succeeded their master as Sect Leader of Wudang. He was the refined-looking old Daoist, Perfected Being[2401] Hyeoncheon.

"I'd hoped to meet them at least once before they left."

Hyeongong answered his Senior Brother's regretful murmur.

"It couldn't be helped. You didn't send me in your place because you didn't want to meet them."

"No, but I still regret missing them. There are the Two Dragons[2402] the Jin Family of Taiyuan and Huashan are so proud of, and I hear Senior Jeok has gained enlightenment as well. I should have seen him."

"Ha ha. Don't be too disappointed. We'll see him again soon."

"Yes, I suppose we will. If what this letter says is true."

Hyeoncheon gazed down at the letter on the table. Across its envelope, written in a bold, soaring hand, were three characters:

Murim Alliance.

Only three characters, yet their weight was unmistakable.

[2399] Perfected Being is a Daoist honorific for a spiritually accomplished practitioner.

[2400] Perfected Being is a Daoist honorific for a spiritually accomplished practitioner.

[2401] Perfected Being is a Daoist honorific for a spiritually accomplished practitioner.

[2402] The Two Dragons are a pair ranked beneath the Ten Kings in Murim gossip.

The Murim Alliance represented orthodox Murim itself. It was also proof that a war rivaling the Great Faction War was approaching.

Is it truly… beginning like this?

Hyeoncheon's expression grew heavy. He could almost hear the screams of the countless Senior and Junior Brothers who had fallen bleeding in the Great Faction War. The horrors of his youth were about to repeat themselves.

This unworthy Disciple finally understands your heart, Master.

Hyeoncheon was thinking of the master who had died after failing to overcome the injuries he had suffered during the Great Faction War when—

"S-Sect Leader!"

An urgent shout came from outside the pavilion.

Hyeoncheon sensed something strange and flicked his sleeve. A soft stream of internal force shot out and flung open the pavilion door.

Hyeongong recognized the face beyond it and frowned.

"You…"

The man who had shouted was a second-generation Wudang Disciple, one of the pursuit party sent after the Killing Ghost. As Hyeongong watched him struggle for breath, his eyes widened.

"Could it be?"

"Yes. We caught him."

"Good! At last, the Killing Ghost who committed those heinous atrocities—"

Hyeongong broke off. His Senior Brother's expression was grim.

And Hyeongong's suspicion was exactly right.

Hyeoncheon silently stared at the second-generation Disciple, who seemed not to know what to do, then spoke in a low voice.

"We ought to be glad you caught the Killing Ghost, yet you look troubled. What happened?"

"Th-that is…"

"Has someone else been killed or injured?"

"No. It isn't that…"

Unable to go on, the Disciple lowered his head.

"We're bringing the Killing Ghost's body here now. I think it would be best if you saw it and judged for yourself, Sect Leader."

"What is this supposed to—"

Hyeoncheon did not have to wait long for an answer.

Half an hour later, Wudang Disciples brought the body before him. He saw what the Killing Ghost truly was and remained silent for a long time before speaking.

"It seems… I have one more reason to go to Henan."

Reflected in the old Daoist's clear eyes was something neither beast nor human.

Chapter 506

Fwoosh.

A northwest wind blew in from the distance, filling the sail. The burly, rough-faced river bandits rowed hard in rhythm, while the bow split the water into white foam that formed and vanished on either side.

Peaceful, as if nothing had happened.

Maybe it was because of all the tragedies we'd seen lately, but the Yangtze, stretching endlessly before us like a sea, looked beautiful today.

As if he'd read my mind, Jeok Cheongang spoke from beside me.

"Same shitty scenery as ever."

"…"

"If I had to pick two things that ought to disappear from this world right now, they'd be Dark Heaven and the Yangtze."

So much for reading my mind.

What could I say? In more ways than one, it was nice that he hadn't changed. I watched his red hair whip in the wind and sighed.

"Don't sigh so loudly. The ground—"

"The ground won't sink just because I sigh."

"No. You'll die by this old man's hand before you set foot on land."

"Wow. You keep exceeding my expectations."

"You seem to have forgotten how to use your eyes while we were apart. One says 'dis,' and the other says 'respect.' What am I to do with them?"

"They say 're' and 'spect,' actually."

"Want me to beat some 'feet-spect' into you?"

"N. O."

Whoosh—whack!

"Ugh!"

Lightning flashed before my eyes. At my cry, and the sight of me clutching the back of my head, Jeok Cheongang flinched.

"I-I barely hit you. What a fuss."

"Does this look like I'm making a fuss? My skull's ringing."

"Your skull is… ringing?"

"I'm tough, but I'm still human. Of course it is."

"…Did it hurt that much? I didn't mean to hit you so hard. Let me see."

He was fidgeting like a puppy that needed to poop. I let out a quiet laugh.

"Why—why are you laughing?"

"No reason."

"…?"

"Ah, I'm all better. Anyway, how long will it take us to reach Henan at this rate?"

At my casual change of subject, Jeok Cheongang's face turned bright red.

"H-how dare you toy with this old man!"

Whack!

"Ah, that really hurt!"

"Just take it!"

It hurt. It really did.

So why did I keep laughing even as he hit me?

Maybe I missed this.

Yes. That was probably it.

Sometimes you miss the little things that never seemed important at the time. For me, it was my father's scratchy beard, which had stung so much when I was young. And it was Jeok Cheongang's palm, gradually growing slower and weaker.

But things were all right now. My father had died long ago, and I could only see him in photographs. Jeok Cheongang, though, had regained his strength.

Whack!

Feeling the speed and power he'd recovered along with his youth made me laugh again.

This is nice, too.

Whack! Whack! Whaaack!

"…Uh, wait a second."

"How dare you make a fool of this old man!"

"Ugh!"

On second thought, it wasn't *that* nice.

There was a limit to how much something ought to hurt. This was crossing it.

My lunatic grin had vanished without a trace. I was twisting desperately to dodge Jeok Cheongang's thick palms when a voice cut in.

"Um… should I come back later?"

Jeok Cheongang stopped dead. I seized the chance to slip away and hide behind the speaker.

My precious meat shield—no, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song—cried out in alarm.

"H-hey, Junior!"

"Junior. That sounds especially nice today, Senior."

"What are you doing?"

"Inheriting your position as Stronghold Lord."

"If you're going to get beaten, get beaten alone!"

"A Senior's supposed to help his Junior at times like this. Don't you want to be that kind of Senior?"

"Why the hell should I—gasp, Great Hero Jeok!"

Unfortunately, Mu Song and I didn't get beaten together.

With the moment broken, Jeok Cheongang lowered his clenched fist instead of bringing it down. He smacked his lips and looked Mu Song up and down.

"Never mind. What is it?"

Mu Song, who had squeezed his eyes shut in expectation of a merciless beating, hurriedly pried me off him.

"I came because I heard you'd called for me. One of my subordinates said you were looking for me…"

"This old man called for you? When?"

"I-I was told you'd asked when we would arrive in Henan."

I'd been quietly watching the exchange. Now I raised my hand.

"Uh, I think that was me."

One of the river bandits must have overheard me mutter it while I was changing the subject and passed it on to Mu Song.

"…It was you, Junior?"

"Yes. I was just thinking aloud."

"I see. I see."

Judging by Mu Song's grim voice, the river bandit who had passed along the wrong information probably would not escape a taste of the Yangtze today.

I turned toward Mu Song, who was glaring somewhere with a dangerous look in his eyes.

"I did want to know, though. When do you think we'll arrive?"

Although Mu Song was startlingly young compared with the other old martial-world veterans, he was still an experienced river bandit who had spent his entire life on the Yangtze.

He took a moment to work it out, then said, "We should be able to cut the travel time considerably. If weather like today's continues, we'll reach Xixia within ten days at the latest."

"Xixia?"

I'd traveled plenty, but not enough to know every place name in the world. In Murim, I'd been too busy to learn them. I'd tried looking them up online in the modern world, but the names and locations didn't always match.

Just look at Dongting Lake.

Here in Murim, Dongting Lake lay in Hubei Province. On a modern Chinese map, it was in Hunan Province.

Discrepancies like that were decisive proof that the two worlds, however similar, were not the same.

"Is Xixia in Henan?"

Jeok Cheongang nodded.

"It's on the southwestern edge of Henan. If this old man remembers correctly, a tributary of the Yangtze ends around there. From then on, we'll have to travel by land. Is that correct?"

"Exactly right, Great Hero Jeok."

"I passed near Xixia during the Great Faction War. Good. Very good."

Was he pleased that Returned to Youth had cured his infirmities of old age and sharpened his memory? Or that we'd be off the Yangtze in ten days at most?

Maybe both.

Smiling with satisfaction, Jeok Cheongang turned to Mu Song.

"Come to think of it, you've had a hard time too. From Sichuan to Hubei, and now all the way to Henan."

Mu Song shook his head, his expression bitter.

"How could I call this hardship? Thanks to it, I can finally lay Uncle Hwang and all the brothers who died before their time to rest. It's what I ought to do, whether anyone asks me or not."

After the Water God Dragon fell, Mu Song and the other river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold had gathered the dead men's bones and scattered them across the Yangtze.

They had lived on the Yangtze and died on the Yangtze. It was an end befitting river bandits of the Yangtze River Channel League.

"They must be grateful to you from the Nine Springs.[2403]"

"Was your name Mu Saeng? For a Disciple of the Seafaring King, you have decent manners. Yangtze One Saber raised you well."

"He was like family to me. And it's Mu Song, not Mu Saeng, Great Hero Jeok."

"Right, Mu Saeng."

"…"

Had his infirmities of old age not been completely cured after all?

For a moment, I wondered. Then I saw Jeok Cheongang glare and realized he was just being stubborn. Whatever Mu Song's name really was, that look said he'd better change it if Jeok Cheongang called him Mu Saeng.

Mu Song swallowed under the aura of a man steeped in the Three Bonds and Five Relationships.[2404]

[2403] The Nine Springs is a traditional expression for the realm of the dead.

[2404] The Three Bonds and Five Relationships are a traditional Confucian framework of social and familial duties.

"What? Why?"

"N-no reason."

"Good, Mu Saeng."

Could anyone else hear dentures clacking?

I took pity on the man who'd lost his name and offered him a hand. Though, really, I was more interested in asking him something.

"By the way, Senior, are you planning to return to Sichuan?"

"Hm?"

"You know why we're heading to Henan, don't you?"

Mu Song understood what I meant. His gaze grew somber.

"You're wondering whether I'll join the Murim Alliance."

"To be honest, yes."

"Dark Heaven's scheme killed someone I looked up to like a parent, along with countless brothers. What would you do in my place?"

"Whatever it took to avenge them."

"So would I. I want to rush there and lend the Murim Alliance a hand right now. But…"

Mu Song bit his lip, then spoke on a sigh.

"I'm only one Stronghold Lord within the Yangtze River Channel League. I have no say in its decisions. Only one person can decide matters of importance for the League: my Master and its Alliance Leader, the Seafaring King."

That was common enough in Murim, where strength commanded respect. A Sect Leader's or Family Head's authority was greater even than that of a conglomerate owner with an iron grip on the family business.

The problem was—

"Typical of a rootless band of river thieves. Then again, it's ridiculous to expect anything from men who weighed the costs and benefits even during the Great Faction War."

Yes. Exactly what Jeok Cheongang had said.

The Yangtze River Channel League had never belonged to the orthodox faction. River bandits scattered across the land like grass roots had gathered beneath its banner because the Seafaring King was strong enough to lead them and promised to protect their individual interests.

I've heard the Green Forest Alliance is much the same.

Both groups had begun as thieves banding together to take what belonged to others. They had survived and grown because they sided with orthodox Murim in the Great Faction War, backed the winners, and were rewarded with recognition of their activities.

They were treated much better than the other unorthodox factions that had survived the war. But grass roots didn't become tree roots just because of that.

Jeok Cheongang gazed at the waves of the Yangtze with displeasure and muttered,

"Before this old man dies, I hope this goddamn Yangtze dries up and withers away. Then that bastard Seafaring King's face will be a complete mess. Tsk, tsk."

"…"

"Think carefully yourself, Mu Saeng. Your Master may make the wrong choice."

"…I don't believe he will."

Despite hearing his Master insulted to his face, Mu Song merely gave a bitter smile. His reaction left me with the vague impression that his relationship with the Seafaring King wasn't especially warm.

But what happens if the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance side with Dark Heaven now?

The answer came quickly.

A real headache, that's what.

If Dark Heaven was a blade approaching from the front, those two factions were daggers stabbing in from behind.

If they decided to harbor ulterior motives, even the mighty orthodox Murim would inevitably suffer a blow.

"The Sword Saint will have quite a headache. I wonder what those two will choose…"

Jeok Cheongang seemed to have reached the same thought. He was muttering to himself when someone spoke.

"Not two. Four."

I turned. Mungyeong stood there, his expression composed.

Chapter 507

I knew Mungyeong was approaching. Seven days and nights of grueling—no, blood-shitting—training had sharpened my usual Qi Sense considerably.

The realm stage shown by the System hadn't risen yet, but I could vaguely sense that I'd have to break through the wall in front of me before it would.

But what does he mean, not two, but four?

The question didn't trouble me for long.

The Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance were powerful enough that even orthodox Murim couldn't afford to dismiss them. And I could think of only one place with factions that belonged in the same set.

Vaguely recalling something Jeok Cheongang had once told me, I murmured, "The Outer Murim."

The Murim beyond the Central Plains. The Murim outside the Murim.

Some people called the barbarians beyond the Great Wall built by an ancient emperor the Outer Lands, but Jeok Cheongang had always dismissed such talk with a snort.

Does the Great Wall surround the whole world? The world beneath the heavens is exactly that—the world beneath the heavens. The lands beneath the sky are boundlessly vast, and each has its own Murim.

Maybe it was just his nature, but Jeok Cheongang's outlook was nothing like the stale Zhonghua[2405] chauvinism you'd expect from an old man of his era.

The records left by earlier Sect Leaders had probably helped. Unlike Jeok Cheongang, who'd been a Lü Bu[2406] stuck at the foot of a mountain whenever he wasn't fighting in the Great Faction War, his predecessors had gone out and indulged their social-butterfly tendencies to the fullest.

Though their records read less like documents written for future generations and more like diaries written for their own satisfaction.

What a shock those had been.

I recalled a few I'd read in Fire Gate Cavern.

Year xx, Month x, Day x. Cheonbong, Third Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan.

I had grown sick of the Central Plains. War raged on all sides, and Murim was a complete mess. So I went to India to broaden my horizons.

After a long journey, I arrived at a river called the Gan… something.

It is not as large as the Yangtze, but it is wide… Anyway, to the younger Disciples of the Fire Gate Clan: if you ever go to India, wash yourselves in that Gan-whatever river first. Do not ask questions. Do not argue.

[2405] *Zhonghua* is a historical term for Chinese civilization. Here it refers to the belief that it stands at the center of the world.

[2406] Lü Bu was a warrior of China's Three Kingdoms era renowned for his fighting prowess.

I was looking around when a mob of bald monks rushed over, shouted things I could not understand, and thrust swords at me. So I beat them senseless.

A Central Plains interpreter who happened to be passing by was horrified. He said they were from India's Small Thunderclap Temple.

From the name, I had assumed they would be like the monks of Shaolin Temple. But these bald monks were violent beyond belief.

When more monks came with an even larger mob, I crippled every last one and burned down their strange-looking temples.

It was a fine sight.

Year xx, Month x, Day x. Songhak, Fifth Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan.

I have always held my Grandmaster, the Third Sect Leader, in the deepest respect. Following in his footsteps, I traveled the world and explored the Outer Murim.

I fought the Mad Wind Society of the great desert beyond the scorching sands, then visited the Potala Palace in Tibet and pulled out its pillars.

As a result, every man and beast in Tibet flew into a rage and chased after me.

But who am I? Songhak, the Ghost Flame Fist and Fifth Sect Leader of the great Fire Gate Clan.

Without suffering so much as a scratch, I… avoided them and returned safely to the Central Plains.

To whoever inherits the Fire Gate Clan's true legacy in the distant future, remember this well.

If you face one hundred First Rate masters, fight them. If you face a thousand, unleash the Dance of the Fire God and Demon. If there are more than that, live to fight another day.

Of course, if you are stronger than I am, just fight them.

Ah, and if you go to that Gan-whatever river in India, jump in and wash yourself immediately. Wash yourself twice.

Year xx, Month x, Day x. Gu Jincheon, Ninth Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan.

I went to Nanman.[2407] I destroyed the Five Poisons Sect.

I went to Persia. I met people who wore things called turbans instead of hero headbands.

They were called Muslims, and they said they believed in a messenger and a prophet.

I said I wanted to meet the prophet, but they told me he was already dead. I could not understand this, so I asked several times. They drew their swords.

I had no choice but to send them to the prophet's side.

[2407] *Nanman* is a historical Chinese term for peoples and lands to the south of the Central Plains; it does not name a single country.

Next was the Ice Palace in the North Sea. There was ice and water everywhere, so I turned back.

To the future Disciple reading this: you go.

Ah, and I learned the name of that Gan-whatever river. The Ganges River. If you go to India, make sure you wash yourself there first. Be sure to wash.

Year xx, Month x, Day x. Han Xin, Twelfth Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan.

This unworthy Disciple followed the records of his ancestors to India and went straight into the Ganges River.

As I washed my hair, I saw a corpse floating down from upstream.

I moved to another spot to wash my body and saw a turd float past.

When I went upstream, I found several hundred people throwing corpses into the river and taking shits.

For fuck's sake, how could you pull this kind of bullshit on me?

"…"

They were unbelievable stories, even now.

I only had to skim through the records to see that whenever something displeased them, they smashed their way through anything and everything, whether in the Central Plains or the Outer Murim.

And telling their successors to bathe in the Ganges was like a sergeant about to be discharged writing "more field training" on a barracks survey out of pure spite.

The old *you get fucked too* mentality.

There were not many more records about the Outer Murim after his shit-water bath in the Ganges left the Twelfth Sect Leader royally pissed off. But once trade routes connecting the Central Plains to the outside world opened, information about the Murim beyond the Central Plains began to flow in.

The two factions Jeok Cheongang was now naming were the closest to the Central Plains, both geographically and in their dealings with it.

"The North Sea Ice Palace and the Nanman Beast Palace."

Their names certainly made their respective locations and characters clear.

At Jeok Cheongang's words, Mungyeong nodded with an infuriatingly bright smile.

"Yes, that's right. My Master told me about them. He visited them long ago, and he said that, from what he saw, neither was inferior to the renowned great sects of the Central Plains."

"…"

"…"

I'd bet everything Hyuk Mujin owned that he'd gone there to kill people.

The instant Jeok Cheongang and I exchanged similar looks, Mungyeong's eyes slowly narrowed.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"…Huh? Oh, nothing."

"Ahem. Nothing at all. Just what I'd expect of the Divine Physician, rushing wherever there are patients."

I had to play along, of course. Jeok Cheongang had received considerable help from him too, so he was in the same position.

As if he had never done anything suspicious, Mungyeong returned to his medical-apprentice persona and continued.

"My Master said the Demonic Cult tried to recruit those two factions first during the Great Faction War. Is that true, Great Hero Jeok?"

"Hmm? Ah."

Jeok Cheongang answered with a reluctant look.

"It is true. To the Demonic Cult, the wicked and unorthodox factions of the Central Plains were branches grown from the same root, so they naturally brought them into the fold. If the North Sea Ice Palace had accepted the Demonic Cult's offer and moved south while the Nanman Beast Palace moved north, the Great Faction War would have taken a very difficult turn."

But neither faction had taken the Demonic Cult's hand.

The North Sea Ice Palace had declared itself cut off from the outside world, as it always had. The Nanman Beast Palace, geographically closer to the Central Plains, had weighed its options and sided with orthodox Murim.

"The Beast Palace bastards only meant to make a show of fighting at first, but later they were a great help. Each of the ferocious beasts they brought could do the work of several First Rate masters. And the Heavenly Eagles they'd trained with their secret methods caught the messenger eagles the Demonic Cult sent all over the land."

The Nanman Beast Palace was practically the public enemy of modern-day animal lovers.

For ages, its people had captured and trained all sorts of creatures from Nanman's jungles. They'd also developed and practiced martial arts modeled on the movements of ferocious beasts.

"Oh, wait. Didn't you say you were close to someone over there?"

Jeok Cheongang frowned at my sudden question.

"Who?"

"The Palace Lord. The Palace Lord."

"The Palace Lord? Ah, you mean the Beast Miao King?"

"Yes, him."

The Beast Miao King was both the lowest-ranking and the most unusual of the Ten Kings.

He was the leader of the Miao people, who were native to Nanman, as well as the master of the Nanman Beast Palace, the region's dominant power.

His achievements in the Great Faction War and his outstanding martial arts had earned him a place among the Ten Kings. But from the outside, the title looked almost like an honorary medal awarded to a foreigner. Perhaps that was why even people within Central Plains Murim were reluctant to mention him.

Why raise up some southern barbarian when we could just add another member of orthodox Murim?

That was supposedly where the claim that the Beast Miao King was overhyped had begun.

"I've met him a few times, that's all," Jeok Cheongang said.

"But I heard the Beast Miao King even came to pay his respects to you in person."

"He did. In broad daylight, some dark-skinned fellow with his upper body bare showed up at my residence. I nearly hit him with a Flame Divine Palm."

Mu Song had been standing awkwardly nearby for a while, looking anxious. Now his eyes widened.

"Is that really true?"

"Would this old man start making up lies at my age?"

"N-no, that's not what I meant. I'm just surprised. My Master has mentioned the Beast Miao King too, but I heard he was short-tempered and arrogant, and that the Martial God was the only person he showed any courtesy to…"

"The Seafaring King? Has that young whelp gone senile already? The Beast Miao King didn't show him courtesy because he's a damn fool. Tsk, tsk."

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue with an expression of utter disdain and continued.

"The Beast Miao King may look like that, but he knows when to show respect. If he were nothing but a brute with strength to spare, do you think the Miao people would have gathered under one banner?"

I had to nod at that.

Small and midsized sects with only a few dozen members disappeared for lack of Disciples all the time, only for others to spring up in their place. The Beast Miao King, meanwhile, was a chief who ruled at least several thousand Miao people.

"So?"

Jeok Cheongang stroked his glossy red beard.

"What do you mean, 'so'? There was nothing special about it. He came to visit and spoke in a soft, ingratiating tone while bringing up a connection with the previous generation."

"A connection between our predecessors?"

"Good grief, you ignorant little fool. You of all people should know!"

“Whoa. What’s wrong?”

Our Old Master had suddenly floored the accelerator and rocketed off.

After giving me a thorough scolding, Jeok Cheongang continued in an irritated voice.

“More than two hundred years ago, the Fifth Sect Leader of our sect destroyed Nanman’s Five Poisons Sect.”

“What does that have to… Ah, wait.”

“Back then, Nanman was like a cauldron standing on three legs. The Five Poisons Sect was the strongest, followed by the Nanman Beast Palace, then Poison Valley.”

“So when the Five Poisons Sect was destroyed, the Nanman Beast Palace rose to the top?”

“That’s right. It absorbed Poison Valley as well and took control of Nanman.”

“Wow, that’s insane. So that’s how it happened.”

“That’s why the Beast Miao King held goodwill toward our sect. It was also one reason he joined the Great Faction War. But did you just dare speak to me informally?”

“…I’ll correct myself. It just slipped out.”

I couldn’t help marveling at how the thuggish behavior of a Sect Leader from generations ago had paid off like this.

More importantly, the Beast Miao King was well disposed toward the Fire Gate Clan, and that was part of why he’d sided with orthodox Murim in the Great Faction War…

“Then there’s a good chance the Nanman Beast Palace will join this Murim Alliance.”

“I can’t say for sure. Even this old man cannot make an easy judgment about that. But if the Beast Miao King I remember is still the same, he will help orthodox Murim.”

“What about the North Sea Ice Palace?”

“If the envoy sent from Henan hasn’t frozen to death on the way, they’ll probably read the letter, at least. I wouldn’t get your hopes up.”

Jeok Cheongang’s seasoned gaze turned toward Mu Song.

“But our more urgent concern is right here. What will the Seafaring King do?”

Mu Song flinched. Then Mungyeong spoke quietly.

“There’s something I’ve been wanting to ask you for a while, Great Hero Mu Song.”

“Uh, yes?”

Mungyeong watched Mu Song’s trembling eyes in silence, then clicked his tongue.

“You know who I am, don’t you?”

“…!”

Chapter 508

“You know who I am, don’t you?”

“…!”

“…!”

The air around us froze. I could hardly believe my ears, and Mu Song’s pupils trembled.

He stared at Mungyeong like he was about to wet himself, then squeezed out a hoarse reply.

“I-I don’t know anything.”

“Is that so?”

Mungyeong regarded him coolly.

“Then why are you speaking formally to me, Great Hero Mu Song?”

“…!”

“You’re a fearless bastard, lying to my face.”

“Gasp!”

He’d walked right into that one. But how had Mu Song figured out who Mungyeong was?

No wonder he kept flinching like a dog that needed to shit.

From the way he’d been acting, Mu Song had known for some time. But given the level of martial arts I’d seen from him, that should have been nearly impossible.

Mungyeong had reached the realm of Returning to Simplicity and achieved Returned to Youth. To see through him, you’d need to be a master in a similar realm. At the very least, you’d have to be past the early stages of Supreme Peak to sense even the slightest thing amiss.

And Mu Song noticed?

No way. I’d sooner believe Hyuk Mujin had knocked Cheongpung down with one punch and sent three teeth flying.

While I was puzzling over it, Jeok Cheongang spoke in a bored tone.

“That’s enough. The fool kept his mouth shut, so he must have meant to pretend he didn’t know and let it pass. An old man threatening a child isn’t a pretty sight.”

“Old man? Threatening?”

Mungyeong snorted.

“Until yesterday, you were moping around like you could die any day. You get a little younger, and suddenly you’ve found your tongue. Stay out of this.”

“…What did you say?”

A deep furrow appeared on the forehead Returned to Youth had left smooth and wrinkle-free.

I hurried between them.

“Wait. Both of you, calm down. Calm down.”

“You, get out of the way.”

“Move.”

“Yes, sir.”

I slipped away without a moment’s hesitation. Mu Song, wedged between the two monsters like lettuce in a sandwich, shot me a pleading look.

Save me, or something like that.

But why should I get my guts burst in a fight between two whales?

I need to save myself first. Besides, they’re not about to have a life-and-death duel.

I was right. After glaring at each other in silence, Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong lowered their auras at the same instant, as if they’d agreed to it.

“Hmph. I’ll let it go since you helped me.”

“What an ungrateful old man.”

They traded remarks like a pair of prim old men in a nursing home, then turned toward Mu Song. He had gone stiff as a statue.

“Come to think of it, you’re a remarkable fellow. How on earth did you know?”

I wanted to know that most of all. I watched Mu Song’s mouth, waiting for his answer, but it came from Mungyeong instead.

“It was them. The boatmen who came along when we went after the imugi.[2408] Or should I say the river bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold? Am I right?”

Mu Song swallowed.

“Y-yes, sir. They said the young medical apprentice named Mungyeong was actually a Supreme Peak master with formidable martial arts, and that his standing seemed high enough to treat even the Zhuge Family Head however he pleased…”

That happened without me knowing?

Well, it made sense. Mungyeong couldn’t have found me by running all over the vast Dongting Lake using Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water.

So that’s how his identity got exposed.

Mungyeong had kept his true identity hidden for decades. Even after the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, apart from his Disciple, the Divine Physician, you could count the people who knew on one hand—including Jeok Cheongang and me.

Mu Song didn’t seem to have guessed he was the Slaughter Saint. Still, Mungyeong couldn’t be pleased that more people knew his secret.

Jeok Cheongang, of course, didn’t care. He looked ready to break out the popcorn.

“You stupid old man. You should’ve disguised yourself. Ha ha ha.”

[2408] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent often associated with dragons.

“There was no time. Every moment counted while I was going to save your Disciple.”

“…Ahem. I do appreciate that.”

Jeok Cheongang stopped laughing dead. Mungyeong clicked his tongue softly and fixed his gaze on Mu Song.

“I clearly warned you through Sound Transmission, but it seems you have more loyal subordinates than I expected.”

“Gasp!”

Mu Song’s eyes widened at Mungyeong’s cold voice. The next moment, he shouted loudly enough to turn every head nearby—if a screen of internal energy hadn’t enclosed us.

“N-no, you can’t!”

“What can’t I do?”

“My subordinates have done nothing wrong! Take my head instead!”

“…Why would I kill you?”

Mu Song, Jeok Cheongang, and I all stared at him wide-eyed.

“What? Y-you won’t?”

“You’re not going to kill him?”

“That old man’s gone mad—wait. Can infirmities of old age spread to other people?”

Jeok Cheongang considered that for a moment, then cried out triumphantly.

“I’ve got it! Instead of killing him, you’re going to cripple his dantian or cut off a limb!”

“…!”

Mungyeong looked at us, his eyes trembling, and muttered with regret, “You’re making me want to kill someone.”

Mu Song spoke, fear and resolve mingling on his face.

“My subordinates are innocent. Please, let me be enough—”

“Shut your damn mouth before I tear it apart.”

“Yes, sir.”

Mungyeong stared down at him in disbelief and sighed.

“Six, including you. Correct?”

“Y-yes, Senior. We’ve been together for many years, and they know how to keep their mouths shut.”

“I have never had a junior like you, and I am no longer a martial artist. But if you fail to keep them quiet, I can make all six of you disappear without leaving a trace.”

“…!”

“If you want to live out your days in peace, keep your mouth shut forever. Don’t tell the Seafaring King. Don’t tell anyone. Understood?”

Mu Song pressed his lips together and gave a small nod. Mungyeong jerked his chin behind him.

“Go. Tell your subordinates to stay away from the stern until we reach Henan.”

“What?”

“Do you have another question?”

“N-no, sir. If you need anything, please call for me.”

Mu Song bowed and hurried away.

That left the three of us: Jeok Cheongang, Mungyeong, and me.

Jeok Cheongang smacked his lips in disappointment and poked me in the side.

“It would be more fun if that fool told everyone. Don’t you think?”

“In—cough.”

I hurriedly buried the rest of *I agree* in a cough.

Mungyeong was glaring our way, plainly not amused. He looked ready to grab the nearest easy target and beat him senseless for finding it funny.

“I didn’t say anything.”

“Neither did I. Feeling guilty about something?”

“No, I just thought I’d tell you that in advance.”

“And I was thinking of giving you a beating in advance.”

“I really didn’t mean anything.”

“I heard ‘in.‘ What came after it?”

Panicking would only make this worse. I answered calmly.

“I meant, ‘Admittedly, I have a conscience. How could I do such a thing?‘”

“That didn’t sound like it.”

“It’s true.”

“No, it isn’t.”

“It is. Why are you playing Gung Ye?[2409]”

Mungyeong didn’t know who Gung Ye was, but he could tell it wasn’t a compliment. I did my best to ignore his chilling gaze and changed the subject.

“Why did you tell them to stay away from the stern?”

“Don’t change the subject.”

“…”

That shut me up.

Mungyeong clicked his tongue at my awkward silence.

“You’ve done well raising this one as your Disciple.”

[2409] Gung Ye was a Korean ruler traditionally portrayed as claiming to read people’s minds.

Jeok Cheongang had been watching with his arms folded, as though none of this concerned him. He let out a quiet laugh.

“It’s because he’s like this that I raised him.”

“This ill-mannered brat?”

“Is that what you think? I thought we were close enough to dispense with formalities. Perhaps we see things differently. Or perhaps someone’s trying hard to ignore that thought.”

Mungyeong looked silently from Jeok Cheongang to me and back.

“…You’re quite the smooth talker. Returned to Youth, and it’s your mouth that’s gained the most vigor.”

I had no idea what they were talking about.

As I stood there trying to follow the conversation, Jeok Cheongang pushed himself away from the swift ship’s wooden railing.

“I’m going into the cabin. I’m sick of looking at this goddamn river.”

“Wow, what a wonderful idea. Are you sure your surname isn’t Zhuge instead of Jeok?”

That was the best thing I’d heard all day. But when I took a step after him, Jeok Cheongang put out a hand to stop me.

Tap.

“Huh?”

“What do you mean, ‘huh’? Why are you following me?”

“You said you were going to the cabin.”

“So?”

“I was just about to go there myself.”

“Two men in that cramped cabin?”

“It’s a five-person cabin. Where’s your conscience—”

“I’m going to circulate my qi and sort through the enlightenment I’ve gained recently. You don’t need to come.”

“Oh, you’re going to circulate your qi. Then I’ll stand guard—”

“No need. Stay here.”

“What?”

Jeok Cheongang snapped.

“I said stay here!”

“Whoa, you startled me. Why are you shouting?”

“Quiet. Follow me and you’ll be sorry!”

“…?”

I stared after him, bewildered. Then I felt someone’s gaze prickling at me and turned.

Mungyeong's stare was drier than the sand by the Sphinx's forepaws.

Fuck. I should've followed him.

What did I care if Jeok Cheongang gave me hell or rang a bell? I'd rather jump into the vast Yangtze than be left alone with a man who might cut off my head—

"The river looks unusually clear today. Don't you want to go in?"

"What?"

What the hell? Could he read minds? Was he really Gung Ye?[2410]

A suspicion flashed through my head, and I found myself looking around for a palace guard with a mace.

That was when—

Whoom!

A mace swung at me.

No. It was a single, swift, stealthy wave of palm force.

I hastily crossed both arms to block it when the sound of splitting air pierced my ears, but the palm force fired by a once-in-an-age master known as the Slaughter Saint was not something I could block so easily.

Boom!

Fuck, that really does feel like a mace.

Pain throbbed in my chest as I flew off the swift ship. Just before I hit the river, I twisted my body, sent the internal energy in my lower dantian into my legs, and stepped onto the water.

Splash!

The calm surface splashed violently, as though I'd stepped into a puddle.

Standing on the water with Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water, I glared at Mungyeong in disbelief.

"What are you doing all of a sudden?"

"The calm river's been disturbed."

"What are you—huh?"

"Your movements are so rough, you might stir up a storm."

Before I could say another word, Mungyeong clicked his tongue and went on.

"Then… it's time to begin."

Ding!

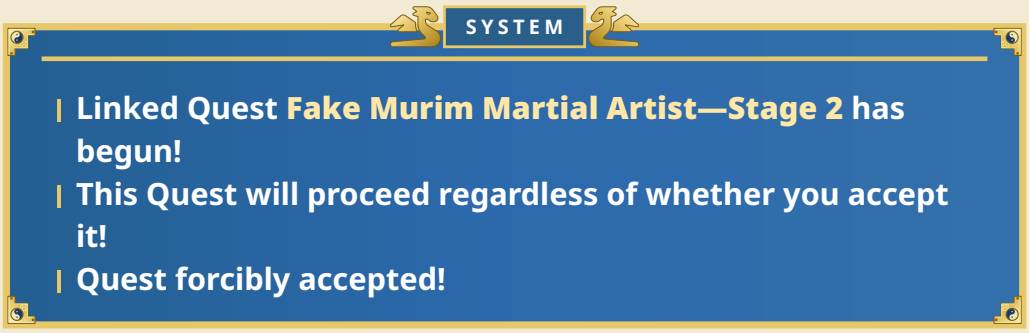
SYSTEM

Linked Quest Fake Murim Martial Artist—Stage 2 has begun!

[2410] Gung Ye was a Korean ruler traditionally portrayed as claiming to read people's minds.

Chapter 509

Ding.



"…?"

What the fuck?

My thoughts must have shown on my face. Mungyeong's eyebrows twitched as he looked at me.

"I clearly told you there would be another training session. Don't tell me you forgot?"

"Excuse me?"

Forgot? Is he messing with me right now?

Dumbfounded, I looked back at Mungyeong.

"How could I forget after shitting blood so many times? Even thinking about it makes my asshole twitch."

"…I understand. Stop there. That's disgusting."

"Ha. Seriously."

The head might forget, but the asshole—no, the body—remembered.

Even now, whenever I closed my eyes, memories of shitting blood day and night came flooding back.

To exaggerate a little, if all the bloody liquid I'd passed over the past seven days and nights were collected in a tub, every mosquito in Hubei Province could gather for a feast.

It was horrible.

Some memories wouldn't go away no matter how hard I tried to forget them. The Linked Quest the System had announced on the day of my last duel with Mungyeong was no different.

It hadn't been long ago, and it was far too important to forget. I'd have to be out of my mind.

"Anyway, I haven't forgotten. I remember every single thing you said back then."

"Is that so?"

Mungyeong studied me.

"Then your reaction makes even less sense. I even warned you in advance. Why do you look as though someone just hit you in the back of the head?"

"…Uh."

Because that's exactly how it feels.

I knew another training session was coming, but I'd been certain it wouldn't happen right now.

There was only so much he could teach me aboard this swift ship, which was even narrower than an ordinary vessel.

At most, a cultivation technique?

But a cultivation technique, the foundation of martial arts and internal energy, was not something that could be swapped out as easily as a machine part.

Especially not in my case.

The Fire Gate Divine Technique was the very root of the Fire Gate Clan. It transformed the nature of our internal energy into fire qi and amplified its power, so the cultivation technique played a far greater role in our martial arts than it did in those of other sects.

Mungyeong of all people had to know that, but I asked just in case.

"Um, you're not planning to teach me a cultivation technique, are you?"

Whoosh! Slash!

I turned my head at the sound of the wind. A throwing blade shot past like a streak of light, missing my neck by a hair before slicing through the river behind me.

"…I heard your answer loud and clear."

"Don't waste my time with that kind of nonsense."

"Of course. I was just asking on the off chance."

Then what is it? Another poison-tasting session?

Foreboding and curiosity struck at once, but I put both aside for the moment. Not for any particular reason—Mungyeong had simply grown much farther away while we talked.

Whoosh!

The favorable wind and the waterway men's sailing experience certainly helped, but the swift ship was several notches faster than an ordinary vessel.

We'd barely exchanged a few words, yet he was already that far away. I almost wondered whether the bastards from the Yangtze River Channel League had installed a motor.

Damn, it's fast.

Even a model student who routinely came first in the entire school was bound to have one weak subject. Mine was movement techniques.

As befitted a Supreme Peak master, I could keep up using Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water, but I wasn't used to it, and it consumed a considerable amount of

internal energy. Unlike on Dongting Lake last time, there was nothing here for me to step on, either.

"I'll climb aboard first and listen. I can't stay out here like this."

Mungyeong nodded readily.

"Do that."

"You're not going to throw a hidden weapon at me as a surprise, are you?"

"I said I understand. Stop talking nonsense and come up."

"Yes, sir."

I concentrated the internal energy I'd drawn up in my toes.

The greatest advantage of the Fire Gate Divine Technique was the explosive force it could produce. One leap would be more than enough to get me back onto the swift ship.

One, two.

Now.

Bang!

The internal energy released from my toes slammed into the water. The river surged upward like a massive wall from the shockwave, and a fierce wind swept across my entire body.

In a moment so brief it could not even be called an instant, I covered over a hundred feet and landed on the stern of the swift ship—

Thwack!

What the fuck?

I went flying back even faster than I'd approached. I hurriedly sent internal energy into the soles of my feet and flipped myself around.

I'd been plunging headfirst toward the river, but I regained my balance just in time to stand on its surface.

What is this, déjà vu?

I looked at Mungyeong, who stood tall on the stern, with a thoroughly displeased expression.

"What was that just now?"

"What was what?"

"That thing in your hand. You hit me with it."

"Oh, this."

Mungyeong waved the large object he was holding.

"This is an oar. It's mainly used to row a boat."

"I wasn't asking because I didn't know that."

"I thought you were."

"Didn't you promise not to do anything strange?"

"To be precise, I said I wouldn't throw a hidden weapon. This isn't a hidden weapon."

"Oh, I see. You used a lethal weapon instead of a hidden weapon."

"Something like that."

Is he insane? Seriously.

Mungyeong stared at me with a profound gaze. No—with a profound gaze at the water rippling around me.

"The Yangtze River is still calm, yet chaos breaks out wherever your feet touch."

"If you keep pulling stunts like this, I'll be the one making a scene. Seriously."

"Do you know why it happens to you in particular?"

"I don't, but why are you doing this?"

Mungyeong ignored my question.

"It isn't because your movements are clumsy and rough."

"You're making my personality rough."

"Every movement a master of a certain realm makes has its own reason and purpose. In your case, the cause is your internal energy itself. It's too violent. This is one of the longstanding problems with the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts."

"Ah, now I'm pissed. I'll climb aboard again, so put down that oar first and—"

I stopped mid-sentence.

This wasn't just Mungyeong being spiteful or playing a prank.

"Wait. What did you just say?"

"So your ears do work. I said the reason your movements are rough on the water is a longstanding problem with the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts."

A longstanding problem…

I couldn't brush that off.

After a moment's thought, I asked, "What does that have to do with Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water? I'm just clumsy because I'm not used to it. Aren't you judging too quickly?"

"You fool. It isn't that simple."

"You mean…"

"The stability and precision of your internal energy."

"Stability and precision…"

"Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water is one measure of those qualities. The more stable and precise your internal energy, the more freely you can perform it. It's an advanced movement technique, but a Peak master with deep enough attainment can use it without much difficulty."

Mungyeong continued without pause, then suddenly leaped down from the stern.

He was far enough away that an ordinary person wouldn't have been able to make out his face. But my senses were keen enough to see and hear him clearly.

Softly, he landed on the water, as light as air. Not a ripple rose around him. It was as though nothing had happened.

Mungyeong turned his dry gaze on me.

“And you?”

“…!”

I instinctively lowered my head and looked at the water beneath my feet. But I already knew what I would see.

The path I’d taken chasing the swift ship was covered in white foam, as though another boat had passed through it.

Splash.

I took a cautious step. Dozens of ripples spread out from it, overlapping one another.

Even compared with Mungyeong, the difference was too great.

“You seem to know the answer yourself.”

I might have felt less embarrassed if he’d sounded scornful. Instead, his flat voice seemed to say, *Yes, that’s about your level.* My face burned.

“Do you understand what I meant now?”

“…I think I understand it to some extent.”

As Mungyeong had said, Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water was an important measure of the stability and precision of one’s internal energy.

Depending on how well you distributed and controlled your power, the water beneath your feet could churn as though caught in a storm or remain as calm as a deserted lakeshore.

“Then tell me what you should gain from this. In your own words.”

“Hmm. I’ll be able to use my internal energy more efficiently.”

“I don’t like that answer.”

“I’ll gain stability and precision, and I’ll be able to produce the same amount of force while using less internal energy.”

“A little better. Still not enough.”

Each second seemed to stretch into a minute as I thought it over. Then the answer came to me.

“Amplification.”

“Explain further.”

“What I’ve said so far would let me apply the right amount of force where and when I need it. If I can control my internal energy that precisely… I can amplify it more than I do now, too.”

“So?”

“This isn’t just about stability and precision. The martial arts I’ve learned will become more powerful. Am I right?”

Mungyeong stared at me in silence before tossing out a single remark.

"…You're not a complete idiot."

That's it. I got it right.

But the strange thrill I felt wasn't from winning a little praise from Mungyeong.

If I can complete this training successfully, I can become stronger than I am now.

I'd hit a kind of stagnation. Maybe I'd grown too quickly. After advancing by leaps and bounds, my martial arts had stopped progressing, and I could feel a high wall blocking my path.

But with this training, I could improve my technique even without gaining some new enlightenment.

So I still had plenty of room to grow without enlightenment.

When had I started thinking about it all wrong? I hadn't tried to fill the space I already had. I'd just kept wanting something newer and greater.

What a stupid thing to do.

It was like owning a one-terabyte external hard drive, filling only five hundred gigabytes of it with porn, then whining that I was out of space.

Mungyeong had shown me that I still had another five hundred gigabytes for porn—no, that I still had room to fill. No need to buy another external hard drive when the first one wasn't full.

Ah, Great Lord Mun.

A halo seemed to shine behind Mungyeong's shoulder.

At the sight of my eyes brimming with those feelings, Mungyeong opened his mouth.

"Keep your eyes straight ahead before I gouge them out."

"…Ah, yes."

"Anyway, you seem to have finally grasped the general idea."

"Yes. I think I get it."

"Then you must know what training you need to do now."

Of course I did. I gave the answer I'd been expecting.

"Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water. Am I right?"

"Yes. Better to experience it yourself than hear and think about it a hundred times. The Yangtze is the perfect place, so start now."

So that was why he'd knocked me into the water without warning. He must have planned this from the beginning.

But I wasn't annoyed or resentful. You couldn't gain anything without paying a price.

It's a little daunting with nothing but river around me, but I'll get used to it if I keep practicing.

I answered without hesitation.

"Understood."

"You're more obedient than I expected. Keep that attitude."

"Yes."

If it meant becoming stronger than I was now, what wouldn't I do?

I bowed to Mungyeong. Then I realized I'd forgotten the most important question.

"Um, by the way."

"Hmm?"

"How long do I have to do this?"

"What a foolish question."

Mungyeong spread both hands as though the answer were obvious.

Ten stars... no, ten shichen?[2411]

"W-wait. Even for me, ten shichen[2412] is impossible. I have to keep up with the swift ship using Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water. You know how much internal energy that'll take—"

"What are you talking about? Ten days."

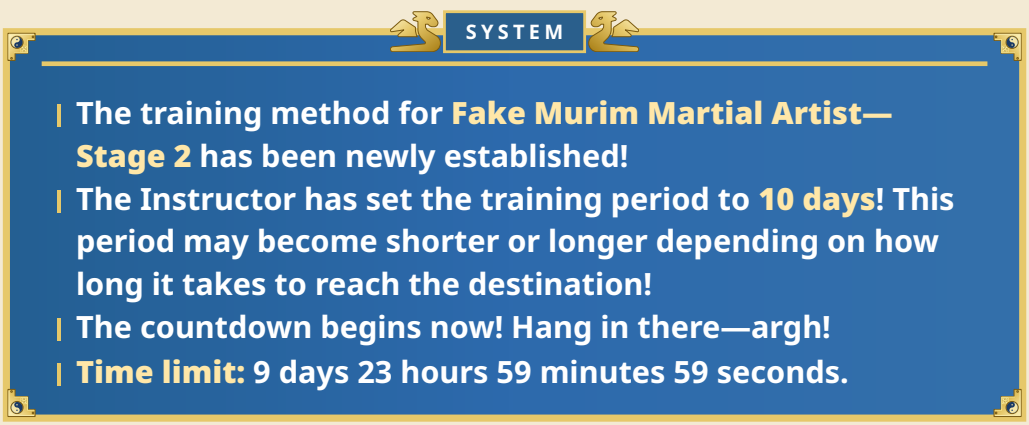
"Excuse me?"

"Not ten shichen.[2413] Ten days. Follow me the entire way until we reach Henan."

"...Excuse me?"

As I froze in place, a familiar notification rang in my ears.

Ding.



"..."

Fuck. I have no words.

[2411] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; ten shichen is about twenty hours.
[2412] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; ten shichen is about twenty hours.
[2413] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; ten shichen is about twenty hours.

Chapter 510

Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song had been a sailor from birth.

His parents, whose faces he could no longer remember, had been a pair of river bandits famous in the area for being inseparable. Both sides of his family were full of river bandits and fishermen, too.

River banditry ran deep in his blood.

Maybe that was why Mu Song much preferred being aboard a boat to being on land.

Dense forests and open fields made his hands and feet tingle and left him short of breath, as though he had swallowed deadly poison. But the sight of a wide-open river or sea brought him back to life.

And that wasn't all. While other stronghold lords who had made fortunes as river bandits bought grand estates and indulged in wine, women, and gambling at pleasure houses, Mu Song decorated his boat, lay on a bed woven from nets, and watched the Yangtze.

Whenever he did, he had the same thought.

I wish the whole world were made of water. Then I could spend my entire life on a boat.

But now, Mu Song was staring blankly at the Yangtze and muttering to himself.

"Ah, fuck. This boat is fucking slow. I want to get off already…"

"…!"

"…!"

The mood turned icy.

The nearby Water Dragon Stronghold river bandits doubted their ears. They rolled their eyes toward one another, exchanged glances, and soon reached an obvious conclusion.

We must have heard wrong!

That's it. All our ears must have gone bad at once.

The Stronghold Lord would never say that.

Everyone in the Yangtze River Channel League knew what kind of man Mu Song was, from the most senior Water Dragon Stronghold river bandit to the youngest recruit.

The very embodiment of a passionate sailor! A man who loved the Yangtze even more than his Master, the Seafaring King!

There was no way a man like that would curse the swift ship he treasured as much as his own life for being slow and say he wanted to go ashore—

"I should quit this whole damn business. Fuck this."

"…!"

"…!"

An invisible shock swept across the deck. Mu Song's sudden talk of retirement left everyone silent, faced with the prospect of Water Dragon Stronghold itself disbanding.

The silence might have gone on forever if a liquor barrel hadn't slipped from a dazed river bandit's shoulder.

Thud! Crack!

Full of liquor, it was heavy enough to shatter when it struck the deck. Alcohol splashed everywhere.

Only then did Mu Song snap out of his thoughts. He glared.

"What the hell are you doing?"

Mu Song already had a fearsome face. The river bandit who had dropped the barrel went pale and bent sharply at the waist.

"I-I'm sorry!"

"You bastard. You don't know the value of liquor? I ought to hang you upside down and… What was it? The Yangtze, the Yangtze… Right. I might just sentence you to the Yangtze's dip-and-taste punishment."

"I deserve to die. Please, anything but that…"

"Watch yourself. I'm in a shitty enough mood without you making it worse."

"Yes, sir!"

"Enough. Clean this up and put everything back the way it was. Bring another barrel of liquor, too."

"Pardon? But…"

"Are you insane? How dare you talk back? Get moving!"

"A-at once, sir!"

As the subordinate hurried away, shouting frantic acknowledgments, Mu Song let out a deep sigh.

Nothing is going right.

It wasn't just a complaint. Nothing was going right.

Even good fortune would not have been enough to make up for it, yet one bad thing after another kept happening.

He had reluctantly left his home base in Sichuan for Hubei. Not long ago, he had also had to part with Hwang Chung, the Yangtze One Saber, who had been like family to him.

Thinking he had to repay the gratitude and grudges he owed Hwang Chung, Mu Song had agreed to take Jin Taekyung's group as far as Henan. And sure enough, the worst had happened.

I was going to keep pretending I didn't know.

An unidentified old master who had clearly achieved Returned to Youth.

That beast wearing the guise of a young medical apprentice had realized that his identity had been exposed.

That monstrous old man. Who the hell is he?

From what Mu Song had observed, very few people in the traveling party knew the truth. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, and Jin Taekyung, at most?

Cheongpung was impossible to predict, but even he quieted down in front of Mungyeong. Chances were he knew, too.

Damn it. If I'd known this would happen, I should've taken the other ship.

Water Dragon Stronghold had two swift ships heading toward Henan. Jeok Cheongang had insisted on splitting the passengers between them because there were so many, and Mu Song hadn't dared defy the Fire King.

Thinking of the Deputy Stronghold Lord traveling comfortably aboard the other swift ship, more than a hundred jang[2414] ahead, was enough to make his stomach hurt.

Compared to this, that ship's a flower garden. A goddamn flower garden.

At least the people aboard the other ship could be reasoned with.

Gung Gibang's smell was a problem you could solve by holding your breath for a moment, and the strange snake Cheongpung called Mimi was surprisingly entertaining to watch when it performed tricks.

But this ship?

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. Fire King Jeok Cheongang. And another old monster hiding his identity.

It was a gathering of monsters.

At least Jin Taekyung, his junior in name only, still spoke politely to him. And after seeing Mu Song so often, Jeok Cheongang treated him more or less like a person.

The last one was the problem.

Those eyes…

Mu Song shuddered involuntarily at the memory of Mungyeong's cold gaze.

One of the senior river bandits, who had been watching his Stronghold Lord's strange behavior for some time, came over and asked cautiously, "Stronghold Lord, are you all right?"

"Do I look all right?"

"Not at all, sir."

"Then why ask? You know what's going on."

"I worry about you, and that's the thanks I get? Anyway, what did that old monster threaten you with to make you look so—mmph!"

[2414] A jang is ten ja, or approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet). A hundred jang is approximately 303 meters (994 feet).

Mu Song's hand shot out at the speed of light and clamped over his subordinate's mouth. His eyes darted around the deck.

Only after checking twice, then a third time, that no one had heard did his anger surge.

"Have you lost your mind? Do you have a death wish?"

"Mmph, phew!"

The senior river bandit finally pulled free and stammered, "I-I'm sorry, sir. It just slipped out."

"I've told you again and again. Neither you nor the others are to say a word about him. Understood?"

"Yes, sir."

The senior river bandit was one of the few who had seen Mungyeong's true identity for himself.

Mu Song sighed deeply at the man's anxious, darting eyes before speaking.

"More importantly, did you make sure everyone understood the orders I gave earlier?"

The senior river bandit nodded.

"Yes, sir. Just as you said, I made it clear they're not to go anywhere near the stern."

"Anyone get suspicious?"

There were dozens of river bandits aboard. With that many people, there was bound to be an idiot or two who couldn't take a hint.

"One did. Chunsam. Even after I said it was your order, he asked me about it three times. Nearly gave me a heart attack."

Mu Song ground his teeth.

"I knew it'd be that bastard. Where's Chunsam now?"

"We dunked him in the Yangtze and hauled him back out. He's been tossed down below. He won't be saying anything like that again."

"Whew. Good work. Keep the others in line even when I'm away. One slip, and every last one of us could end up drowned at the bottom of the Yangtze along with the swift ship."

Mu Song's expression darkened.

As if the monster known as the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, weren't enough, now an unidentified old monster who had achieved Returned to Youth was aboard as well. Mu Song almost missed the days when he hadn't known.

Seeing his mighty Stronghold Lord look so vulnerable, the senior river bandit asked anxiously, "At this rate, are we ever going to make it back to Sichuan? We've already been away from the Water Dragon Stronghold for nearly two months. I'm worried it might stay vacant forever."

“Don’t say such unlucky things. They say you can survive even in a tiger’s den if you keep your head.”

“That’s a tiger. Against a Returned to Youth Supreme Peak master, I don’t think keeping your head a hundred times over would help…”

Come to think of it, he was right.

Mu Song had no answer. He shut his mouth.

That was when a voice came from behind him.

“I brought the liquor barrel. Where should I put it?”

There was only one person who would be talking about a liquor barrel right now.

Irritation flared. Without even turning around, Mu Song snapped, “I’ve been letting it slide, but that useless bastard has been getting on my nerves since—”

“Did you just call me a useless bastard?”

“…Huh?”

A moment passed that felt like an eternity.

The senior river bandit was staring over Mu Song’s shoulder, mouth hanging open. Mu Song knew at once that he was thoroughly fucked.

Something else he’d forgotten flashed through his mind.

Ah. I left a spare liquor barrel at the stern.

No wonder his subordinate had started to say something when Mu Song told him to bring another one, then stopped.

Mu Song felt faint. He hadn’t been afraid even when he was caught in the whirlpool at Tianling Falls, but now he was sweating enough to bathe his neck in it.

“Great Hero Mu Song.”

Mu Song squeezed his eyes shut. Then he slowly turned around, forcing a smile.

The one person he never wanted to meet, even in his dreams, was standing there.

“O-oh, Mungyeong. W-what brings you here?”

“Nothing in particular.”

Mungyeong smiled like any other boy his age.

“I was watching the Yangtze from the stern when your subordinate came by. He said Great Hero Mu Song had ordered him to bring a liquor barrel…”

“I-I did?”

“Didn’t you?”

“Well, I… I don’t remember giving an order like that…”

A river bandit appeared behind Mungyeong with a barrel on his shoulder and called out briskly, “Stronghold Lord! I brought the liquor barrel you ordered!”

Mu Song fought down the urge to tear the man’s mouth apart.

“I… I do remember giving that order. Yes. I did. It was a clear mistake.”

“A mistake. I see.”

Mu Song felt Mungyeong’s gaze travel from one part of his body to another.

It had to be his imagination that made him feel as though Mungyeong was looking at his lethal acupoints.

Fortunately, perhaps his desperate wish had reached the heavens. Mungyeong soon withdrew his gaze and spoke.

“Great Hero Jeok was beside himself with rage. He said that if it happened again, you’d better be prepared.”

Of course, Jeok Cheongang hadn’t flown into a rage or said anything of the sort.

But Mu Song wasn’t stupid enough to miss what Mungyeong meant.

“Y-yes, I understand. Tell Great Hero Jeok I’ll bear it in mind. But…”

“Go ahead.”

“What if someone absolutely has to go to the stern? For ship’s business, say. Or to bring meals.”

Mungyeong thought for a moment before answering. “Great Hero Jeok told me to pass along instructions for that, too. If it’s ship’s business, you’re to come alone and take care of it. And you’re to deliver the meals yourself.”

“…You mean I have to do all that alone?”

“Would you rather not?”

Mu Song’s face went rigid.

“It’s been my lifelong wish. I couldn’t be happier.”

“I see. Then I’ll be going. See you at dinner.”

Mungyeong headed back toward the stern, leaving Mu Song behind. Then he stopped and turned around.

“Oh, and one more thing.”

“What else? Is there still something you need to tell me?”

“Two portions will be enough for each meal until we reach Henan.”

“Huh?”

“Young Master Jin is going to have no appetite for the time being, so keep that in mind.”

They had at least ten days left before they reached Henan. No matter how poor someone’s appetite was, going ten whole days without eating was absurd.

Curiosity got the better of Mu Song. He mustered his courage and asked, “Um… did something happen to Junior Jin?”

“Oh.”

A dimple appeared beside Mungyeong’s mouth.

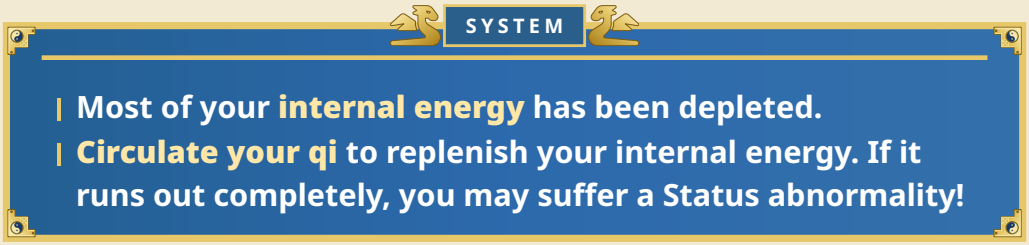
His smile was so natural that even Mu Song, who thought of him as a monster, mistook him for an innocent boy for an instant.

“He must be busy right now. Very busy.”

Sometimes I feel like I've become a human smartphone.

A System window had appeared before my eyes, much like the warning you get when your battery falls below fifteen percent.

Beep.



But why was I more puzzled than alarmed?

If I ran out of internal energy right now, I'd sink in the middle of this vast stretch of the Yangtze. Yet the danger bothered me less than the questions.

And one reason for that was surely the presence of something approaching from far away.

Ssssh.

A large body drew closer with remarkable stealth. The fin poking above the water looked oddly familiar.

No, fuck.

Why the hell was there a shark in the Yangtze?

Chapter 511

Deep in the night, with darkness on every side, two ships raced along the Yangtze under full sail.

Whoosh!

Any sailor with good night vision would have been startled once by the vessels' extraordinary speed, then twice by the flag visible beyond their faint torchlight.

The Yangtze River Channel League.

Those five characters, written in blue dye, were a sure pass for traveling safely and freely across the vast Yangtze.

But the flag was both a pass and a symbol of raiders.

"What the…"

"Th-the Yangtze River Channel League! They're river bandits!"

"Eek!"

The passengers aboard a pleasure boat, who had been holding a feast on the water, fell into a panic. The fishermen hauling in their nets some distance away reacted differently.

"What the hell are they screaming for? They ought to get back to guzzling their booze."

"Pay them no mind. It's not like this is the first time. But is that the swift ship the Yangtze River Channel League's so proud of?"

"I've seen one before. It's damn fast, so that must be it."

"If I had a ship like that, I wouldn't want for anything."

"How many more fish are you planning to catch?"

"What are you talking about? If I had a swift ship, why would I keep fishing to make my fortune? I'd become a river bandit on the spot."

There was only a hair's breadth between a fisherman and a river bandit. When making a living got hard, a man could take the net and harpoon he'd used to catch fish just days before and turn to raiding.

Perhaps that was why the fishermen showed no particular fear of the river bandits.

"Oh, they're coming this way."

"Let them. They won't rob us."

"Damn it. We're so poor even river bandits won't rob us."

The fishermen chatted as they watched with keen interest.

Fishermen were as tough as any sailors on the river. Even a green river bandit who knew nothing of the world left them alone. He might come looking for a few coins and end up skewered on a harpoon.

The Yangtze River Channel League saw it much the same way. Robbing fishermen for a few coins wasn't worth the trouble.

So the fishermen watched as though it were someone else's house on fire.

But a little while later, when the swift ships picked up speed and disappeared, they tilted their heads.

"Huh? They're just leaving?"

"So they are. Think there's a young master from some powerful family aboard that pleasure boat? Someone they'd regret crossing?"

"They didn't even stop to check who was aboard."

"Forget it. What does it matter? Let's finish hauling in the nets and get home before it gets any later."

"Yeah, all right."

Once the two swift ships had vanished without incident, lively music rose from the pleasure boat again. The fishermen smacked their lips, then turned back to their work.

Half a shichen[2415] later, a strange cry rang out from somewhere.

"Kkyat-meu!"

At first, the fishermen thought little of it.

"Good grief. They ought to show some restraint. They're making an awful racket."

"Someone over there knows how to party."

"I'm already half dead from exhaustion, and now I've got to listen to 'Kkyat-meu'? I ought to punch a hole in the bottom of their boat."

The graying fisherman who had muttered irritably pulled on his net again.

That was when another cry rang out.

"I'm going! I'm going! I'm going! Zoom, here I go!"

"Yeah, yeah. I'm coming right now, you bastards."

The fisherman snatched up his harpoon, eyes rolling back in fury.

"Fuck this. I'll hurry over, punch a hole in their hull, and come right back, so nobody try to stop me."

"Wait. Just wait a moment."

The other fishermen had finally noticed something odd. They pricked up their ears.

"That… doesn't sound like it's coming from the pleasure boat."

"You're right. Then what is it?"

"The sound came from over…"

As if on cue, they all raised their heads and looked around for its source.

[2415] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

The music stopped abruptly aboard the pleasure boat as well. Apparently wondering what was going on, men and women dressed in dazzling silk stood at the bow and stared out at the pitch-black Yangtze.

“Did we hear wrong?”

“I definitely heard something strange.”

“Huh. It’s not like a ghost’s bewitched us.”

Just as everyone began to doubt their ears—

Whoooosh!

Water roared as it was violently split apart, and a person appeared.

No, strictly speaking, he wasn’t alone.

“…Oh, my.”

“W-what the hell is that?”

Everyone stared wide-eyed at the uninvited guest.

It was astonishing enough to see a young man crossing the Yangtze in the middle of the night, bare from the waist up. But when they recognized the enormous creature swimming ahead of him, bound by some strange rope, they could hardly believe their eyes.

“A s-sa-eo! It’s a sa-eo! A man’s riding a sa-eo!”[2416]

The shout shattered the silence that had settled over the river.

And everyone realized that the bizarre noise they had heard was part of the reality unfolding before their eyes.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

A sa-eo. A monstrous fish with a huge, hideous body and a vicious nature, said to devour even humans.

And now one was swimming with a man riding behind it.

What was more—

“T-there’s more than one!”

“One fin, two… five! There are five sa-eo!”

It was a shocking sight. Sa-eo mostly lived in the open sea; seeing even one in the Yangtze was rare. Seeing five together was almost unthinkable.

But if that had been all, the fishermen wouldn’t have stood there speechless.

The reason they had been rendered speechless was simple.

“Tell me… am I dreaming?”

“I think I’m having the same dream.”

“It looks to me like that young man has put some sort of bridle on the sa-eo and is, well… driving it.”

“I don’t know what that is. It’s frightening…”

[2416] *Sa-eo* (□□) is a Sino-Korean word for “shark,” distinct from the ordinary Korean word *sang-eo*.

Just as the fishermen said, each of the five sa-eo wore something like a bridle. A faintly glowing rope was wound around their snouts, its ends held tight in the young man's hand.

"Turn left!"

The young man shouted and pulled his wrist.

Whoooosh!

The sa-eo all moved left at once.

"Turn right!"

He twisted his wrist the other way.

Whoosh!

The sa-eo changed course with it.

With their great stamina and speed, the five sa-eo cut through the water ahead while the young man followed, keeping himself atop the river on his two feet.

They were every bit as fast as the swift ships that had passed earlier—faster, if anything.

"What in the world am I looking at?"

As someone muttered in a daze, the young man closed the distance in the blink of an eye and waved to the fishermen.

"Welcome, fishermen."

"…!"

"Sorry to ask when we've only just met, but could you give me directions? Did two ships pass through here earlier? Maybe half a shichen to one shichen ago?"

The fisherman who had been planning to attack the pleasure boat lowered his harpoon and answered awkwardly.

"W-we saw 'em. You mean the swift ships?"

"That's right. Yangtze River Channel League. There's a kid standing at the stern who looks like he has one hell of a nasty temper."

"I-I don't know about the kid. But the swift ships went that way. About half a shichen ago."

"Half a shichen? I've almost caught up. Whew, fuck. I damn near shit blood getting here."

"…?"

The fisherman paused at language as colorful as anything he'd heard from a sailor. Just then, the young man loosened the strange rope in his hand.

The fishermen belatedly realized that one of the sa-eo had been released and panicked.

"Urgh!"

"Th-the sa-eo's loose!"

"Back! Back! Row!"

But what they feared didn’t happen.

The sa-eo merely blinked at the young man as meekly as a crucian carp. The young man looked unconcerned.

“Sa-eo? Oh, you mean a shark.”

“W-what do you think you’re doing?”

“I know what you’re worried about, but my boy doesn’t bite.”

“Your boy?”

“I’ll show you. Here, fin.”

The fishermen’s eyes bulged.

No sooner had the young man held out his hand than the sa-eo, its eyes darting about, offered him its fin.

“See? He listens. I told you he’s a good boy.”

Not good. More like he’d been *made* good.

The fishermen swallowed the words before they could reach their lips.

The sa-eo’s ragged fin and trembling body were just their imagination. They had to be.

Whether he noticed the fishermen staring at his muscles or not, the young man went on calmly.

“He’s got anger-management issues, but he’s been controlling them fine since I beat the shit out of him. You’ll be all right. You won’t get another chance like this, so take one off my hands.”

“P-pardon?”

“As thanks for the directions. I need to let them go soon anyway. Got anything to eat? I’ve had raw fish three meals a day, and my stomach feels like an aquarium.”

The fisherman had no idea what was happening, but instinct told him what would be best for his safety. Trembling like a leaf, he handed over the food tucked inside his clothes.

“H-h-here.”

“Ah, yes. Th-thank you.”

The young man took the lightly seasoned rice ball and flashed a playful grin.

“Then catch lots of fish.”

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

That was the last they saw of him.

The fishermen stared blankly as the sight of one man and four fish vanished into the distant darkness in an instant. Then they looked at the only trace he had left behind.

Shudder!

The sa-eo had foolishly picked a fight with the wrong person, been thoroughly beaten, and now feared human beings themselves. The shark—or rather, the white sturgeon—trembled violently.

And the fisherman who had become its new owner realized that his fate had just changed dramatically.

"…I guess I don't need a swift ship anymore."

That was the moment a new Morning Star was born among the river bandits.

I guarantee no one in either the modern world or Murim has ever experienced water skiing as eco-friendly as mine.

Whoosh!

"Shark number four. Your posture's slipping."

Flinch!

"Yeah, you. The one who just flinched. What, are you an individualist?"

Swish!

"Just keep going like that. You're not going alone. Match fins with your friends and go together."

Of course, I'd used a little violence.

A few punches hadn't been enough to satisfy them, apparently, because they kept coming at me. So I worked over their fins and pulled out a few teeth.

If an environmental group had seen me, they'd have called me a destroyer of nature whose crimes outraged heaven and humanity, and a fish abuser doomed to suffer even after death.

I hadn't cared from the start.

It's not like I'm Shanks.[2417]

A bighearted guy who gives up an arm because a shark looks hungry only exists in old comic books.

I caught one, taught it a lesson, then called over more of its kind and founded the Shark Water-Ski Team. I called it the Catch-'Em Fish Farm.

Still, I wouldn't have made it this far without them.

I looked fondly at the team members who had carried out their mission so well.

Over half a day of alternating between rest and travel, I'd replenished some of the internal energy that had bottomed out and closed much of the distance to the swift ships. Their reward for all that hard work was freedom.

"All right, everyone. Off you go."

[2417] Shanks is a character in the Japanese manga *One Piece* who loses an arm saving a boy from a sea creature.

I was untying the ropes around their snouts—or rather, the Water God Dragon's sinew I'd stashed away last time—when a voice reached my ear.

"…Would you look at this lunatic."

I turned my head.

Beyond the deep darkness, someone was walking toward me across the surface of the water.

Chapter 512

“…Would you look at this lunatic.”

The voice was thick with disbelief, and the red hair stood out even in the deep darkness.

I widened my eyes at the last person I expected to see.

“Oh? What brings you here?”

“That…”

Jeok Cheongang hesitated, his voice trailing off.

“I got seasick, so I got off the ship for a bit.”

“Ah, seasick. The Old Master got seasick.”

This wasn’t just any Supreme Peak master. This was the Fire King himself.

Spider-Man retiring because he was afraid of heights would have been more believable than Jeok Cheongang suffering from seasickness.

“What’s with that smile?”

I forced down the corners of my mouth and answered.

“I just have one of those faces that looks like it’s smiling.”

“Want me to make it look ready to die?”

“No, thank you.”

“If you have a complaint, say it to my face. Don’t grin at me like a creep.”

“I never said I had a complaint. But what are you hiding behind your back?”

“H-hiding? What would this old man be hiding?”

“The thing you’re holding in your clasped hands. Whatever could it be that you’re so embarrassed you have to hide it? Are you some kind of Murim high-school girl boss?”

“I said I’m not hiding anything!”

Jeok Cheongang shouted at my sharp observation and awkwardly brought his hands out from behind his back.

He was fiddling with something wrapped in a large leaf, and the conflict in his movements was obvious.

Looks like food. And damn, does it smell good.

The meaty aroma carried on the wind was incredible. My stomach had spent more than half a day digesting nothing but raw fish and grilled fish, so of course it began to churn.

Grrrrowl.

“Is it pork?”

“Beef.”

“You didn’t catch it fishing, did you?”

“Of course not. It was loaded onto the ship beforehand. Those river bandits rubbed it with spices and grilled it. It’s quite good.”

“That sounds delicious.”

“Two people could be eating it while five dropped dead, and neither would notice.”

“That sounds like deadly poison.”

“It’s that delicious.”

“Then give me some. Let me taste it.”

“Hah. You’re not even funny. Did you think I brought it for you?”

“Ah, so you packed it for yourself?”

“Of course.”

“So you got seasick and abandoned the swift ship. It sailed off and left you in the middle of a river you hate, but you still made sure to bring food…”

I looked at Jeok Cheongang and slowly nodded.

“That makes perfect sense.”

“…!”

“Give it here.”

Jeok Cheongang answered gruffly.

“Here. Stuff your face.”

“Why, thank you.”

“I brought it for myself, but I’ve lost my appetite. That’s why I’m giving it to you.”

“I know. I know everything. Why do you keep explaining something the whole world already knows?”

“…Damn it.”

I let his grumbling go in one ear and out the other as I devoured the meat.

By the time my short but fiercely fought meal was coming to an end, the four sharks that had been circling nearby while watching me warily had disappeared from sight. So had the swift ship that had been faintly visible in the distance.

“Ah, I missed it.”

“The sa-eo[2418]?”

“No. I was going to let them go soon anyway.”

“Then the swift ship?”

I sucked the seasoning off my fingers.

“Yes.”

“You don’t seem particularly disappointed for someone who missed it.”

“I’ve got no reason to be.”

[2418] *Sa-eo* is a Sino-Korean word for shark; the ordinary Korean word is *sang-eo*.

"What a strange fellow. Didn't you use the sa-eo[2419] to chase the swift ship all the way here so you could catch up?"

He was right. I couldn't deny it.

But…

"I was starting to regret it."

"Regret?"

"Yes. Regret."

"Why?"

"Because doing it this way… there's no point."

I'd caught the sharks and come this far under the excuse that I needed to replenish my internal energy. But the closer I got to the swift ship, the harder it became to ignore the unease I felt.

Maybe that was because I'd gone against the way I'd lived until now.

I'd let myself grow lax without realizing it.

I already had power I could never have imagined in the past. Enormous wealth, fame, and the attention of the world followed my name like tags.

Maybe I'd gotten carried away by the rewards that came with it all.

I wouldn't have done this before.

To obtain something, you had to pay a price equal to its value.

If I had still been the F-rank Hunter who had secured a home for my family in an expensive Safety Sector far beyond our means and thrown myself into raids without rest to pay my mother's hospital bills, I would never have used some cheap trick involving sharks.

Neither would the version who'd endured a year of brutal training on Mount Jiuhua without ever fleeing back to reality.

"I should've stayed back there and held on to a reef."

Jeok Cheongang frowned at my half-joking complaint.

"Then you'd have fallen even farther behind the swift ship."

"So what if I did? I'd have learned something for every bit of distance I lost."

"You might never catch up before we reach Henan."

"That's fine. Catching up isn't the goal."

Jeok Cheongang's stiff expression slowly relaxed.

"You realized the most important thing in half a day."

I lowered my head toward him. At that moment, I couldn't bring myself to meet his eyes.

"It took me a whole half day. I'm sorry."

[2419] *Sa-eo* is a Sino-Korean word for shark; the ordinary Korean word is *sang-eo*.

“At first, I waited because I was worried about you. After that, I meant to give you a thorough scolding.”

From Jeok Cheongang’s perspective, it must have been utterly absurd. He had even outsourced my training, only for me to put together a Shark Water-Ski Team and use a cheap trick.

But his voice was gentle now.

“I did mean to scold you… but this will do. Try to catch up on your own strength from here.”

Jeok Cheongang stepped forward. The ripples spreading from his toes were far gentler than mine.

He noticed me watching and tossed out a remark.

“Our sect’s martial arts have an especially violent flow. It took me years to calm that storm on my own.”

“Years…”

“You already know this isn’t something you can learn overnight.”

“I know. I also know that it isn’t overnight. There are still ten days left.”

I shrugged and added,

“And I have two excellent advisors beside me to show me the way. That should make it a lot easier for me than it was for you, Old Master.”

The Fire King and the Slaughter Saint. Both were far stronger than I was, and both had traveled the path I was on long before me.

Those were much better circumstances than Jeok Cheongang had faced when he’d had to figure it all out for himself.

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh.

“Look at this sly bastard. Proudly announcing you’ll take another shortcut.”

“I’m hurt that you’d call it a shortcut. Most people call this a fortuitous encounter.”

“Hah. You certainly have a way with words.”

“But you’re not denying it.”

“Because, now that I think about it, you’re right. But that isn’t the only difference between us.”

“…?”

“Martial talent. With that outrageously excellent body and talent of yours, you should be able to sprout at least one bud before reaching Henan.”

A towering tree and a gorgeous flower both began with a single small bud.

It had taken Jeok Cheongang years to bloom. For me, it would be different.

He watched me in silence for a while, then spoke abruptly.

“I can’t see the ship anymore. I’d better hurry after those damned bastards.”

"Take care. If you run into a sa-eo[2420], catch it and try riding it."

"So you don't intend to come with me."

What a mischievous old man. He'd already guessed, but he was testing me anyway. I let out a quiet laugh.

"I'll follow in a little while."

"A little while? It'll take you half a day."

"It still doesn't sit right with me. So yes, that's the plan."

"Tsk, tsk. You certainly know how to make life difficult for yourself."

He said that, but he couldn't hide the smile tugging at his mouth.

Jeok Cheongang looked at me for a moment, then turned and shot off into the darkness.

Even after he dwindled to a speck and vanished, I stayed where I was for a long time.

At last, the sun rose, and the sunlight began to heat the river.

Splash.

I stepped forward through the rough current.

The goal was the swift ship—no, Henan.

The entire Murim world seethed like water in a cauldron.

What had begun as a simple rumor spread in every direction on the lips of gossipmongers. Then one day, dozens—hundreds—of messenger pigeons rose from Mount Song in Henan, each carrying a letter that would turn the rumor into fact.

To all of Murim.

The letters began with that brief sentence and were delivered across the land. Those who learned their contents realized the truth.

An era of upheaval had arrived, and no one could avoid it.

The New Murim Alliance.

An old veteran of the martial world, his body covered in scars, remembered the Great Faction War, when corpses had piled into mountains and blood had run in rivers. Young martial artists born in peaceful times, who had never lived through those horrors, were swept up in all manner of emotions.

"The time has come."

"At last…!"

Troubled times gave birth to heroes.

[2420] *Sa-eo* is a Sino-Korean word for shark; the ordinary Korean word is *sang-eo*.

Some could not hide their excitement at the thought that their chance to make a name for themselves had arrived.

“H-how can this be?”

“So it’s finally come to this.”

Others trembled at the thought of the death soon to come.

But the orthodox Murim of the present era was the victor proven by history.

Hadn’t even the mighty Demonic Cult failed to take the Central Plains and been driven back decades ago?

A bloody storm had swept through Shaolin and Sichuan, but to most martial artists, that was a reason to be angry and fight—not to retreat in fear.

“Anyone with the spirit to fight, any martial artist who bears a weapon—stand beneath the Murim Alliance’s banner!”

The call rang out across the land.

And some answered it.

“Shaolin of Mount Song requests to join the alliance.”

“Huashan will join the Murim Alliance as well.”

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families.

The fifteen pillars that supported Murim began to move.

Shaolin Temple and Huashan were the first to raise the Murim Alliance’s banner. The other renowned sects and great factions soon rushed to request membership too.

In crowded markets, pleasure houses, and inns, gossips talked of little else day after day.

“Have you heard? They say the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families have all joined the alliance.”

“It’s only been a day since the news broke. Already?”

“You’re behind. Of course they have. The question is what the other sects will do.”

“I heard the Shandong Yue Family plans to join too.”

“That’s a surprise. Aren’t they in an awkward position between Murim and the authorities?”

“Any news from the Hahou Sword Family?”

“I understand the former Family Head died in the Great Faction War. The current Family Head will probably join the war to avenge his father, if nothing else. Everyone knows Dark Heaven is the Demonic Cult’s successor by now.”

“The Murim Alliance is the symbol of orthodox Murim. The problem is those who practice demonic and heterodox arts—and the Outer Lands.”

Even as the gossips talked, people throughout Murim were making their own moves.

And as the fervor spread like wildfire, ten days passed.

Chapter 513

Xixia in Henan Province, situated along a tributary of the Yangtze, was packed with people again today.

Boats of every size crowded the ferry landing. Merchants stood beside piles of goods, haggling with fire in their eyes.

“Come on, cheap, cheap! Musk that’s good for your virility! Just one silver nyang!”

“I don’t need that crap.”

“You there, lovely Young Lady! Wouldn’t you like a hand mirror?”

“I’m not buying that crap.”

“…What a pair of fucking assholes.”

Every kind of noise rang through the marketplace.

But in the end, the atmosphere of a place depended on the kind of people gathered there. The merchant who stopped a passing young martial artist out of habit had picked the wrong man.

“Sir, you look like a martial hero on your way to Mount Song. Could I interest you in a well-honed wea—ah!”

The merchant broke off with a gasp. The handsome face that had first caught his eye no longer registered.

The moment he saw the three characters embroidered in black thread across the young martial artist’s dark blue silk uniform, along with the dragon pattern, the merchant let out a cry that sounded almost like a moan.

“B-Black Dragon Demon Gate!”

“…!”

Though the cry had not been particularly loud, the four-character name Black Dragon Demon Gate was enough to plunge the bustling thoroughfare into a pit of silence.

“B-Black Dragon Demon Gate?”

“It’s them. The unorthodox bastards making a name for themselves in Gansu.”

“I heard they arrived in Henan late yesterday… Could they be here to join the alliance?”

Silence spread in an instant. Merchants stopped calling out, commoners stopped wandering, and even the armed martial artists traveling in groups halted to look toward the cry.

Under all those eyes, the young man from the Black Dragon Demon Gate smiled at the merchant.

“You have a good eye for a merchant, recognizing our sect’s insignia.”

“Th-that’s…”

“You don’t seem to have much to do with Murim. Are you from Gansu? Or did you pick up a little knowledge from the Third Rate swordsmen who come here as customers?”

He glanced over the merchant’s shoulder at the weapons neatly arranged on the stall and clicked his tongue.

“Nothing but cheap junk. I wouldn’t take any of it for free. Show me your best.”

“Pardon?”

“Ah, I forgot you’re a merchant. Not your best, then. Your most expensive.”

“Y-yes, sir.”

With trembling hands, the merchant pulled out an iron chest he had tucked deep inside the stall and opened it. The young martial artist whistled at the lone sword inside, lying there without even a proper scabbard.

“Hm. This doesn’t belong in a place like this.”

The onlookers, especially the martial artists, found themselves nodding. The sword looked quite old, but its blade gleamed in five brilliant colors, and its edge had lost none of its sharpness.

It could easily be called a famed sword.

The merchant sensed greed in the eyes of several martial artists and drew his shoulders in.

“M-my late father left it to me.”

“Was your late father a martial artist?”

“Th-that’s impossible. Somehow, he came to own the sword, but he only told me to keep it secret from others and preserve it as a family heirloom for generations…”

“No wonder. There must have been plenty of people who wanted a sword like this.”

Too much greed led to bloodshed. Most martial artists would rather take a famed sword by force than pay several hundred silver nyang for it. Threatening someone with a cheap iron sword was far easier than coming up with the silver.

“Your late father must have been quite wise.”

“Y-yes. He was.”

“But it seems you didn’t inherit his wisdom, bringing it out like this.”

“Th-that’s…!”

The merchant could not finish. The young martial artist let out a quiet laugh. He knew exactly what the merchant had swallowed back.

The man facing him belonged to the Black Dragon Demon Gate, an unorthodox faction. With a knife at his throat, the merchant had no time to think things through. Fear that he might lose his head if he tried to pass off another weapon had paralyzed him.

This was a first for the merchant. For the young martial artist, it was familiar.

“I understand. Most people who meet me think and act just as you did.”

The young martial artist looked the merchant up and down. The merchant sat with his mouth shut, like someone who had swallowed his tongue.

“So I’ll save you.”

Suspicion flickered across the merchant’s eyes.

“Wh-what do you mean?”

“I’ll pay for the sword and take it.”

“Ah!”

The merchant’s face lit up. His heart had already been burning with anxiety. He had brought out the sword because staying alive came first, but now more than a few people had seen it. Once this young man left, wandering martial artists and petty thieves would surely catch the scent and come after him.

If the young man bought it, though, that problem was solved. He would still have to leave the area soon—there would be people after the silver he received—but he could keep his life and take enough money with him to live comfortably elsewhere.

The merchant finished calculating and bowed at once.

“G-Great Hero, if you would do that, I couldn’t ask for anything more!”

“You’re not completely clueless.”

With a quiet laugh, the young martial artist tossed a money pouch from his robes onto the stall.

Clink.

It landed with a weighty rattle. The merchant opened it and blinked.

“G-Great Hero. This…”

The young man had taken the sword from the chest and was examining it from every angle. He glanced over.

“What is it?”

“I’m afraid you may have the amount wrong.”

“The amount?”

The merchant swallowed hard at the young man’s puzzled look. The sword was a family heirloom, and by its value alone, he ought to receive at least several hundred silver nyang. The sum in the pouch was absurdly small.

“Twenty silver nyang is a little…”

“I disagree.”

“Pardon?”

“That’s plenty. I deducted the price of your life.”

The young man’s voice turned cold. So did the air around him.

The commoners watching with mingled curiosity and fear shuddered. The neighboring merchants who had shared the man's hardships deliberately looked away.

But not everyone there stayed silent.

"The Black Dragon Demon Gate must have quite a reputation if even some wet-behind-the-ears brat is throwing his weight around like this."

A rough voice rang out, and the crowd parted. A middle-aged man walked through the gap, baring yellow teeth in a grin at the young martial artist.

"I won't waste words. Put down that sword and get the hell out of here."

The young man blinked.

"Were you speaking to me?"

"Ha! Look at this brat. Who else would I be talking to?"

"Don't misunderstand. I heard you perfectly well…"

He looked the middle-aged man up and down before continuing.

"I just never imagined someone like you would dare say it to my face."

"…Someone like me? Say something like that?"

The middle-aged man stared at him for a moment, then burst into laughter.

"Someone like me! Ha! Hahaha! You're funnier than you look."

"How strange. No one in Gansu ever told me I had a talent for comedy."

"Boy, what's your name?"

"I have no reason to tell you, and no intention of doing so. Be on your way."

"You don't look so good. Scared?"

"Not really… I just find talking to someone like you unpleasant."

"Heh."

The middle-aged man laughed, but his eyes gleamed ominously. His scarred, heavily muscled arm was about to move when the young martial artist spoke.

"That's enough, Blood Cudgel."

"…!"

The middle-aged man jerked at the sound of his sobriquet. The martial artists watching were startled too.

Enough was known about Blood Cudgel Do Sangho that his appearance and the red cudgel at his waist made him fairly easy to recognize. What surprised them was the young man's attitude.

Here was a brat in the Black Dragon Demon Gate's uniform, speaking to an accomplished Peak master as though he stood far above him.

Blood Cudgel sensed something was wrong as well.

"You… knew who I was?"

"I'd heard of you. Heard there was a man who'd lick a beggar's ass for silver."

"…!"

His polite speech had vanished, replaced by open insult. Blood Cudgel's eyes widened with rage as the young man went on.

"Now that we've met, it seems what I heard was true. How about an offer?"

"An… offer?"

"I'll give you silver. Lick the top of my foot, and I'll let you live."

"H-how dare you!"

Blood Cudgel trembled. He was a Peak master whose martial prowess no one could dismiss. He wanted to rush forward and smash the brat's head open.

But the name Black Dragon Demon Gate held him back. The young man was so young, yet so calm. Blood Cudgel had a gut feeling that a life-and-death duel with him would not end well.

"…Damn it."

He lowered the weapon he had half-raised. The young martial artist smiled.

"You must really like silver. Ready to lick the top of my foot?"

"You bastard! Shut your mouth!"

His shout, laden with profound internal energy, struck in every direction. Third Rate martial artists whose skills were still meager groaned and stumbled backward. Terrified commoners screamed.

Through the chaos, Blood Cudgel glared at the young man with bloodshot eyes.

"I don't know how important you are, but one day you'll regret what happened here."

The young martial artist clicked his tongue softly.

"You're angry. But I think you'd better stop there."

"I, Blood Cudgel Do Sangho, may forget a favor, but I never forget a grudge! I'll retreat today, but the next time we meet will be the day of your funeral—"

Thud!

Blood sprayed in every direction.

The young martial artist looked at Blood Cudgel's corpse, its head crushed, and sighed.

"I was trying to avoid bloodshed if I could. You could have held back a little longer."

When had he appeared?

An eight-foot-tall man who had crushed Blood Cudgel's head with a swing of his massive two-section staff answered in a halting voice.

"Dare… insult Young Sect Leader. This subordinate… will not tolerate it."

"Well, Blood Cudgel should be all right. You could hardly call him orthodox."

The young martial artist clicked his tongue. Only then did the people grasp what had happened and scatter in every direction, screaming.

"S-someone's been killed!"

"Aaaah!"

"What the hell…!"

Even the martial artists had frozen at the sudden violence. Just then, the young man spotted something beyond the fleeing crowd.

"See? I knew there'd be trouble."

A group of monks in yellow kasayas[2421] was approaching.

"Shaolin Temple…"

[2421] A *kasaya* is a robe worn by Buddhist monks.

Chapter 514

Shaolin Temple, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim.[2422]

Whenever turmoil descended on the Central Plains, Shaolin had been at the forefront of the fighting. It had been so a thousand years ago, a hundred years ago, and during the Great Faction War several decades earlier.

They had shed more blood than any other sect in the Murim for it, but no one at Shaolin Temple regretted a drop.

It was what they ought to have done. They had fought for a brighter future, for a greater cause.

The monks making their way along a well-paved road held that same conviction in their hearts.

Whoosh!

Their yellow kasayas[2423] whipped in the wind.

Not a breath of wind stirred on that clear spring day, but the monks' swift movement techniques raised a wind of their own.

"Xixia is in sight."

There were twenty Shaolin monks. At the words of the martial monk leading them, a middle-aged monk nodded.

"Good. We won't be late."

"Yes. The appointed time is around shenshi.[2424] We still have nearly one shichen.[2425]"

Xixia covered a broad area, but these martial monks had reached a considerable realm. Even at an ordinary walking pace, one shichen[2426] was more than enough time to reach its ferry landing.

Having made the calculation, the middle-aged monk shook the Zen staff in his hand.

Clatter.

The martial monks understood the signal and stopped short.

Halting a movement technique at such speed in an instant spoke to the depth of their martial-arts mastery.

The middle-aged monk regarded them with satisfaction, then slowly turned.

Behind them stood someone with a conical hat pulled low over their face.

[2422] Mount Tai and the Northern Dipper are prominent landmarks used together as an honorific for a preeminent authority.

[2423] A kasaya is an outer robe worn by a Buddhist monk.

[2424] Shenshi is a traditional time period corresponding to approximately 3–5 p.m.

[2425] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2426] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"We're about to enter the main road. The commoners may be alarmed. May we slow down from here?"

The middle-aged monk spoke with utmost respect. Beneath the hat, tightly pressed lips parted.

"Please do."

The voice was so hoarse that there was no guessing the speaker's age. Grief and pity flickered across every face, including the middle-aged monk's.

"Thank you for granting permission, Martial… Uncle."[2427]

That form of address still felt unfamiliar. The middle-aged monk turned, and the others resumed walking toward Xixia.

Then—

"Aaaaaah!"

"M-murder! Someone's been killed!"

Faint screams and shouts carried from far away.

Before the middle-aged monk, with his profound internal energy, could alert the other disciples, the person in the conical hat spoke.

"It seems we should hurry."

"…!"

Whoosh!

Twenty figures came hurtling through the wind.

At the sight of their fluttering yellow kasayas[2428] and the grim faces drawing rapidly closer, the young martial artist of the Black Dragon Demon Gate frowned.

"Shaolin…"

They were the last people he wanted to meet, especially now, when his simple-minded subordinate had killed someone in the middle of a main road.

"You idiot."

Thwack!

The eight-foot-tall giant[2429] groaned as the blow struck his shin.

"Young Sect Leader. This subordinate hurts."

"That's why I hit you. I told you to be careful. Why must you act without thinking?"

"He deserved to die."

[2427] "Martial Uncle" addresses someone of the generation above one's teacher within a martial lineage; it does not imply a family relationship.

[2428] A kasaya is an outer robe worn by a Buddhist monk.

[2429] The source describes the giant as eight *cheok* tall. One Korean *cheok* is approximately 30.3 cm (11.9 in), making eight *cheok* about 2.42 m (7 ft 11 in).

“Whew. There’s no getting through to you. Fine. The water’s already spilled. What can we do?”

“We should find a way to put it back.”

At the curt voice, the giant blinked his calf-like eyes.

“Young Sect Leader. Not this subordinate.”

“You don’t have to tell me. I already know.”

The young martial artist turned with a faint smile. Facing the stern middle-aged monk five steps away, he offered a fist-palm salute.[2430]

“An honor to meet Shaolin’s esteemed monks. I didn’t expect to meet Master Jung Ho quite so soon.”

The middle-aged monk, Jung Ho, twitched his thick eyebrows.

“You know me? I don’t believe we’ve met.”

“We haven’t, but I’ve heard plenty about you.”

“This humble monk has no reputation worth speaking of. Nor am I worthy of being called Master.”

“Just as my father said. You really are modest.”

“Your father?”

“He once told me about an exceptionally fiery-tempered monk at Shaolin—ah, a monk of deep Buddhist faith who follows his principles to the letter.”

The young martial artist glanced at the Zen staff in Jung Ho’s hand.

“He also said you wield a Zen staff like a demon. One hung all over with prayer beads.”

“…Amitabha.[2431] You have a sharp eye.”

“I’m glad you’re the man I thought you were. This would have been rather embarrassing otherwise.”

Jung Ho regarded the young martial artist with a grave gaze, then spoke abruptly.

“That is fortunate. As I listen to you, a few things occur to me as well.”

“I’m listening.”

“Your clothing belongs to the Black Dragon Demon Gate of Gansu. Your aura and bearing are far from ordinary. You must be its Young Sect Leader, whom I’ve heard of only by reputation. Am I right?”

The young martial artist smiled and bowed his head.

“Allow me to introduce myself properly. I am Sama Pyo, Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.”

“I’ve heard much of the Black Dragon Saber. They say you’re a Morning Star in no way inferior to the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

A murmur passed through the monks behind Jung Ho.

[2430] A fist-palm salute is a traditional martial greeting made by covering one fist with the opposite palm.

[2431] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

The sobriquet Black Dragon Saber was that widely known. And as the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, a force counted among the three strongest unorthodox factions, Sama Pyo possessed an impressive background as well.

But none of them saw the sneer that brushed across Sama Pyo's lips as he lowered his head.

When Sama Pyo looked up, he was smiling broadly.

"You praise me too highly. For Master Jung Ho to think so well of an unknown nobody like me—I hardly know what to say."

"I will say it again: I am not worthy of being called Master. Nor do I mean to overestimate you. I speak only of what has been proven. However…"

Jung Ho looked at the corpse lying facedown in a pool of blood.

"I do not yet know the facts surrounding this unfortunate man's death."

Sama Pyo rubbed his stubbled chin.

"Well, that's a long story."

"There is no need to worry. There is a faster way."

Clatter.

At Jung Ho's signal, a lean martial monk stepped forward and examined the body.

Before joining Shaolin, he had traveled as a wandering martial artist and accumulated a wealth of experience. It did not take him long to identify the corpse.

"It's Blood Cudgel."

"Blood Cudgel Do Sangho? Are you certain?"

"Yes. His head was crushed, but I am certain."

"Blood Cudgel. Blood Cudgel…"

Jung Ho ran his fingers over the prayer beads tied to his Zen staff, then turned to Sama Pyo.

"Did you know?"

"Know what?"

"That Blood Cudgel killed five innocent merchants in Shaanxi two days ago and has been on the run since?"

"Did he?"

"He must have thought himself safe because he did it in a remote mountain area. Bold enough to come all the way to Henan, at any rate."

"…Good heavens. What a monstrous man."

Sama Pyo made a show of frowning.

Blood Cudgel's crime wasn't what troubled him. What troubled him was the intelligence network that had uncovered and relayed the deed of an experienced wandering martial artist in just two days.

Is this the Murim Alliance's reach, or Shaolin's strength?

Blood Cudgel Do Sangho was a fairly well-known wandering martial artist, but that was because his methods were cruel and he went around boasting about himself.

The Murim was full of masters far above his level. To know this much about a man like Blood Cudgel suggested an intelligence network woven as tightly as a spiderweb.

Not welcome news… Then again, after everything that's happened, I suppose it makes sense.

Sama Pyo gave nothing away.

"How fortunate."

"What is?"

"The water I spilled turns out to have been rotten. You might say I dealt with it before anyone could drink it."

Jung Ho's gaze darkened.

"You were not unaware of that fact."

"The outcome was good. Doesn't that settle it?"

"How you reach an outcome matters just as much. Whatever you say, killing a man on a busy main road was unwise."

"It was a dangerous situation. He had to be killed before he killed me. Ah, of course, that was not my intention either."

Sama Pyo pointed to the eight-foot-tall giant[2432] beside him.

"This fellow did it."

The giant blinked his bulging eyes.

"Young Sect Leader. A person?"

"We must make the facts clear. Wipe the blood off that vicious two-section staff before you make excuses."

"That. True. Blood Cudgel killed. Me."

"Please be generous with him, Master. He's skilled in martial arts, but his head is a little…"

Sama Pyo put a finger to his temple and twirled it. Jung Ho watched him in silence before speaking.

"You—or rather, the Black Dragon Demon Gate—will have to explain this properly."

"Of course. This happened because I failed to control my subordinate. I'll cooperate in any way I can."

[2432] The source describes the giant as eight *cheok* tall. One Korean *cheok* is approximately 30.3 cm (11.9 in), making eight *cheok* about 2.42 m (7 ft 11 in).

“As you know, tensions have been high of late. The commoners in particular are afraid.”

The Murim was a powder keg about to explode.

Even an illiterate old villager who had never finished the Thousand Character Classic[2433] knew the Murim Alliance was no social club for martial artists. During the Great Faction War, the fighting had engulfed more than the martial artists of the Central Plains.

“If someone is openly killed on a main road in broad daylight at a time like this, people will inevitably look on us unfavorably.”

“I’ll bear that in mind.”

“Blood Cudgel may have been a criminal on the run, but those above us may still hold you accountable for his death.”

“I’ll gladly explain myself.”

“You must apologize to the commoners nearby as well.”

“Don’t worry. I’ll even compensate them if they wish.”

Jung Ho’s eyebrow twitched.

Though he was a martial monk, he had spent many years at Shaolin following the Buddhist path.

He was displeased that this had happened, and he was not particularly impressed by the attitude of the Black Dragon Demon Gate’s Young Sect Leader, whose reputation he had already heard.

But what could he do? Sama Pyo was nodding along obediently, at least on the surface. Jung Ho could only turn away.

“Then… that will be all.”

“We have met by fate. Why don’t we move somewhere else for a while?”

“Amitabha.[2434] I’m afraid I must decline. There is a guest I must receive.”

Jung Ho looked anything but regretful. He was about to turn when—

“The sword.”

“Hm?”

“You don’t appear to use a sword.”

The voice was hoarse, like metal scraping against metal. Someone wearing a conical hat pulled low over their face continued.

“That sword doesn’t seem to belong with you. Return it to its owner.”

“Ah, this?”

Sama Pyo smiled faintly as he looked at the sword in his hand.

“It’s mine.”

[2433] The *Thousand Character Classic* is a classical text traditionally used to teach Chinese characters and literacy.

[2434] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

“Not to my eyes.”
“If you don’t mind my asking, who are you, Monk?”
“That has nothing to do with this.”
The smile at the corner of Sama Pyo’s mouth faded.
Then someone shouted from far away.
“The Jin Family of Taiyuan! It’s the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

Chapter 515

The chaos in the marketplace clearly hadn't reached the ferry landing yet.

If it had, no one would be shouting like that.

"The Jin Family of Taiyuan! The Jin Family of Taiyuan is here!"

"Waaaah!"

The main road was some distance from the landing, but everyone still gathered there could hear the cheers carrying from afar.

Black Dragon Saber Sama Pyo was among them.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan…

His gaze darkened.

In less than two years, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had grown into a formidable power. Though perhaps "newly risen" wasn't quite right for a family with three hundred years of history and standing behind it.

And one man had brought that fading great family back to prominence.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

The young man had once seemed like a sprout with no hope of growing. Now he had put down deep roots in the soil of the Murim and was growing into a mighty tree.

Every branch connected to him was thick and flourishing.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang. Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung. Cheongpung's master, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak, and Huashan, one of the strongest powers among the Nine Sects and One Gang.[2435] Then there were the prestigious sects Taekyung had forged close ties with during his travels through the martial world.

And among them was Shaolin Temple, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim.

"I wondered what sort of guest would bring Shaolin's Discipline Hall Master all the way here to greet him. Now I know."

"Amitabha.[2436] This humble monk is not a man with time to spare."

Jung Ho fixed Sama Pyo with a stony look.

"Nor am I so easygoing that I'll stand by while someone starts a pointless quarrel."

"Ah."

Sama Pyo took his hand off the hilt of his saber. He hadn't noticed it settling there.

"My apologies." He smiled. "Force of habit."

"I hope that is true."

[2435] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a grouping of major orthodox martial-arts sects and the Beggars' Gang.

[2436] Amitabha is the Buddha of Infinite Light. His name is also spoken as a Buddhist invocation.

“I know how to conduct myself. Surely you don’t think I’d show disrespect to Shaolin.”

“Amitabha. It would be best to refrain from actions that could invite misunderstanding, Benefactor Sama Pyo.”

“I will. But…”

The smile at the corner of Sama Pyo’s mouth grew more pronounced. He looked from Jung Ho to the unidentified monk whose conical hat hid his face.

“For a devout Master like you to speak so firmly, he must be someone you care for a great deal.”

Jung Ho’s title alone made it clear that he held no minor position in Shaolin. His master had been one of the three disciples of Hong Dao, the late Abbot of Shaolin and Dharma King.

By both office and seniority, Jung Ho was a leading figure within the temple. Sama Pyo suspected his open hostility had less to do with temperament than with the identity of the monk beside him.

“I’ve heard you haven’t taken a Disciple yet, Master.”

“…You have sharp ears.”

“And a keen eye, as you know.”

Jung Ho frowned.

“Amitabha. Enough wordplay. Let us leave this for another time. We must greet a guest who has arrived earlier than expected.”

“Ah, I see. Have you taken on a new Disciple?”

“Benefactor.”

Woom.

The Zen staff in Jung Ho’s hand gave a low, resonant hum.

Then the person who had been watching in silence spoke.

“It’s all right, Martial Nephew.”

“…!”

“…!”

A voice as rough as metal scraping against metal came from beneath the low brim of the conical hat. The air seemed to grow heavy around it.

Jung Ho and the other Shaolin monks trembled at the immense internal energy in that voice. Beside Sama Pyo, the eight-foot-tall giant opened his bulging eyes wide.

But it wasn’t only the monk’s aura that startled Sama Pyo.

Martial Nephew? Did he call Jung Ho his Martial Nephew?

As Sama Pyo stood momentarily frozen, the monk in the conical hat spoke quietly.

“Return the sword to its owner. Here in Henan, we will tolerate no disturbances.”

“…!”

“If fate brings us together, we shall meet again.”

That was all. Having let the words fall as lightly as if he were giving them to the wind, the monk turned and disappeared. The Shaolin monks followed him.

Sama Pyo watched them go without a word.

The giant turned toward Sama Pyo and spoke in his halting voice.

“Young Sect Leader. That monk. Who is he? I cannot beat him.”

“…”

“No hair. But skill. Very strong.”

He recalled the faint righteous gleam he had glimpsed in the monk’s eyes beneath the conical hat at the final moment, then muttered.

“The Discipline Hall Master’s young Martial Uncle.”

The glimpse had been brief, but enough to judge his age. The face beneath the hat had been astonishingly young. And yet…

“Young Sect Leader?”

“Yes, I heard you, you idiot.”

Sama Pyo returned from his thoughts and clicked his tongue softly. He tossed the sword back to the merchant cowering and trembling in a corner, then looked up at the sky and stretched.

“Come on. I could use a drink.”

“Pleasure house! Pleasure house!”

“Yes, yes.”

The sky was blue, and heroes who had roamed the Murim were gathering in Henan.

Far off, the crowd at the ferry landing kept calling the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s name.

“I apologize for troubling you, Martial Uncle.”

On the way to the ferry landing, Jung Ho quickened his steps to draw alongside the monk in the conical hat. The monk shook his head.

“It wasn’t your fault, Martial Nephew Jung Ho.”

“No. I should have settled the matter myself. I never imagined that young Benefactor would behave that way…”

Jung Ho’s displeasure showed plainly on his face. Sama Pyo’s conduct still rankled.

At a time like this, on a main road under countless eyes, the young man had not only beaten Blood Cudgel to death but had also tried to provoke one of Shaolin’s senior figures.

“I’d heard the Black Dragon Demon Gate held considerable power in Gansu, but its Young Sect Leader is more insolent than I expected.”

“Is that so?”

The voice beneath the hat was rough, but the monk’s manner was perfectly calm. He kept walking as he spoke.

“My experience is limited, and there is still much I don’t know. But I’ve heard that those who follow demonic, heterodox arts are not especially powerful.”

“That is true of most. Not every unorthodox sect is the same.”

“The Black Dragon Demon Gate is an exception, then.”

“Yes. Among the unorthodox sects of the Central Plains, it could easily be counted among the top three. It may even be their greatest rallying point.”

“What do you mean by ‘rallying point,‘ Martial Nephew?”

“What it represents, Martial Uncle.”

“What it represents…”

“The Black Dragon Demon Gate has the longest history of any unorthodox faction in the Murim. It was once one of the Twelve Branches of the Demonic Cult.”

“Did they betray the Demonic Cult?”

“Amitabha. I think ‘compromise’ would be more accurate.”

The Black Dragon Demon Gate’s compromise had succeeded. Victory in the long, brutal war had ultimately gone to the orthodox faction, but the Black Dragon Demon Gate had drawn together the unorthodox martial artists scattered like grass roots across the Central Plains, recovered from its losses, and grown stronger.

“But for its Young Sect Leader to behave with such arrogance… Shaolin suffered enormous losses in that bloody conflict. To look down on us now is—”

Jung Ho broke off.

As though he could read his thoughts, the monk beside him spoke softly.

“It’s all right. Don’t let it trouble you, Martial Nephew Jung Ho.”

“…Martial Uncle.”

“Everyone in Shaolin was deeply wounded. Some lost the Senior Brothers and Junior Brothers who had shared their hardships. Others lost Disciples. I’m no different.”

Step. Step.

Step by step, their pace quickened. The rough voice continued from beneath the hat.

“I was… more grief-stricken than I thought I could bear. But just because that person has gone somewhere he can never return from doesn’t mean his will has vanished too.”

Jung Ho and the other Shaolin monks bit their lips.

How could they forget that day? How could they fail to understand his grief?

They all remembered. They all knew.

“I will carry on his will—my Master’s will. That one thought carried me through my time in Repentance Cave.”

The skin glimpsed beneath the conical hat was as rough as the monk’s voice, covered with countless scars.

For the unnamed monk, the past three months had been like hell.

Every day, he had repeated treatment and training while writhing in terrible pain. Those who heard the screams echoing from Repentance Cave could not keep themselves from shedding tears.

Three months of anguish and suffering.

But he had endured. Bearing the grief of his master’s death and his anger at the killers, he had kept going.

And at the end, enlightenment had come to him like a single ray of light.

“Martial Nephew Jung Ho.”

“Yes, Martial Uncle?”

“My Master would sometimes say this. Everything begins with one person. If one is not enough, then two. If even that is difficult, then three should step forward. That is how we raise up what has fallen and move onward.”

His master, who had gone where he could not return, had loved wine and meat.

He would lie on a rock and sleep all day, waking only when the world had grown dim. Then he would shake the shoulder of the Disciple who had come to wake him and fallen asleep beside him, and point high into the night sky.

Look. You’re up there too.

The Disciple, rousing himself with disheveled hair, would rub his eyes and ask in return.

Why do you call that star your Disciple?

Because I followed that star when I first went to bring you back.

But… it’s so small and faint.

That’s why it’s a good star.

What?

The star that shines brightest and clearest will soon disappear. Yours will stay there and light the sky for a very long time.

The Disciple still remembered what his Master had told him that day.

Even after a long time had passed, the heavenly patterns had become distorted, and a new star had risen somewhere in the north.

Even on the day his Master departed on a distant road and the grounds of Shaolin were stained with blood.

He remembered. Part of him still lingered in that place, on that day.

Master. Where is my star now? Have you become a star somewhere in the sky? Are you watching over me?

He stopped on a hill overlooking the ferry landing and raised his eyes to the clear blue sky.

There were no stars to be seen. Even after nightfall, he would not know which was his. He would not find his master's star, either.

However hard he looked, all he could see were two ships moored at the landing and people filing down from them. However closely he listened, all he could hear were the cheers of the crowd gathered thick as clouds.

Master. Where are you?

He gently closed his eyes. But there were no stars in the darkness behind his eyelids, and no matter how intently he listened, his master's voice did not come.

Today was no different.

He was about to open his eyes and face that truth once more when—

Splash!

"A person! Someone was running across the river and fell in!"

"Gasp! That's… our youngest!"

Screams. Someone's startled cry. Then a voice he knew, desperate and unmistakable.

"Fuck, don't just stand there screaming! A rope! Throw me a rope!"

Light flickered before his eyes, where a moment ago there had been nothing but darkness.

It was the Morning Star that had risen in the north. A trace of his master.

Have you come?

A smile formed on the stiff lips of the monk in the conical hat, Unnamed.

Chapter 516

The closer you get to your destination, the harder the last stretch feels. That's human nature. After ten days and nights of pushing my body to its limits, I had nothing left to squeeze out.

Dad, I'm coming.

Was this really how a father and son were going to reunite after so long? That was the moment the strength drained from my flailing limbs.

Grab!

My fading vision snapped back into focus.

Someone had caught my wrist. Through my ears, muffled by all the water that had gotten in, I heard a voice.

"Trying to go before this old man? What a rotten little punk."

When had he gotten here? Jeok Cheongang had closed the distance from the ferry landing in an instant. He looked down at me with a grin.

The moment I saw his face, all the tension left my body.

"…Hah."

As I exhaled the breath I had been holding, Jeok Cheongang's grin deepened.

"You're still breathing, at least."

"That's amazing. Am I still alive?"

"Listen to this fool. Yes, you're alive."

"Then stop looking at me and pull me up. I think I'm actually about to die."

"Such an exaggeration. You're a hundred years too early for that."

Whoosh. Drip.

He hauled me up by the wrist. River water poured off my swollen body, taking the weeds clinging to it along.

"Do you see them?"

"Who? God?"

"The people waiting for you."

Exhausted, I blinked. The crowd gathered like clouds at the distant ferry landing was rapidly drawing closer, and I could make out several familiar faces among them.

Cheongpung, waving both arms frantically. Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin, their eyes opened wide. Jin Wikyung, who was practically bawling his eyes out.

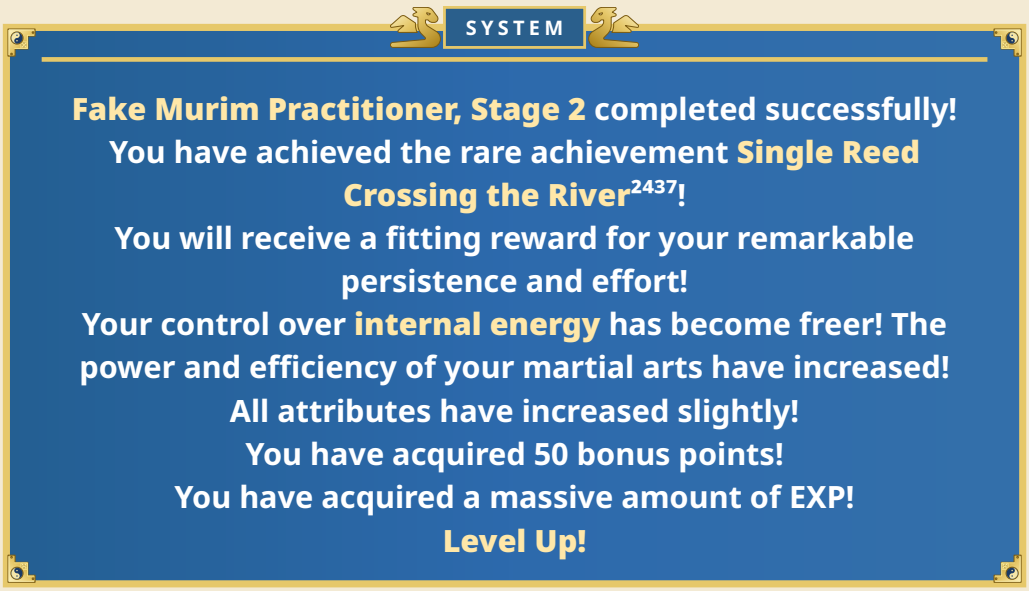
And… Mungyeong was quietly watching us.

—Welcome to Henan.

With that brief Sound Transmission, Jeok Cheongang landed, holding me in his arms.

At the same time, a clear ringing sounded in my ears.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



System notifications rang out one after another, and holographic windows filled the air.

The Level Up message came with a welcome lightness in my body. Then a wave of sleepiness washed over me.

“...Old Master.”

“Hm?”

“Don’t wake me.”

Those were my last words before my eyelids grew heavy and the sleep demon took me.

Where am I?

That was my first thought when I opened my eyes.

I blinked slowly and looked around. Pitch-black darkness surrounded me. As my eyes adjusted, I finally made out where I was.

A swamp.

Yes, this was a swamp.

White bones of uncertain origin—human or beast—were scattered everywhere, and a horrific stench filled the air, strong enough to make me gag.

Worse, my body was moving on its own.

Splosh.

[2437] Single Reed Crossing the River alludes to the legend of Bodhidharma crossing a river on a single reed.

My bare foot, without even a shoe on it, stepped into the sticky mud. I struggled with all my might to stop, but my body had already escaped my control.

One step. Then another.

I was slowly sinking deeper into the swamp when—

Whoooosh.

A wind blew from somewhere, making the skeletal trees that filled the swamp shudder.

Beyond the darkness, an unidentified red light rose.

…What's that?

It wasn't a flame. It looked more like someone's eyes.

The chilling gaze held not a trace of warmth. It stared at me as if to say, *Come closer if you can.*

If this were an ordinary protagonist from a movie or novel, he would struggle and crawl toward it…

You come here, asshole.

Fuck the cliché.

I'd already sized up the situation. After everything I'd been through lately, I was apparently having a nightmare. I didn't need to play along.

An ordinary person would have felt the urge to piss himself the moment he saw those red eyes, but I was the kind of person who felt the urge to use Flame Divine Palm.

There was just one tiny problem…

Splosh. Splosh.

Ah, fuck.

My body kept moving forward whether I wanted it to or not.

Slowly, steadily, as though trying to swim with my lower half sunk deep in the swamp.

But I knew I'd never reach those eyes. I would sink out of sight before I met whatever they belonged to.

Fine. Let's get this over with.

I'd almost resigned myself to it when—

Crack!

Gasp!

Something tightened around my neck.

My eyes flew wide. A huge body covered in smooth scales filled my vision, and a low hiss sounded in my ears.

A snake?

No, it was too big to call a snake. A python was more like it.

Its thick body coiled around my neck, then bound both my arms.

Hngh.

Damn it. Had dreams gotten a graphics patch? Why was this so vivid?

The rotten mud had reached my neck. The stench in my nostrils made me gag.

Unable to move, I sank farther into the swamp—and met that red gaze.

…!

A chill shot up my spine.

A vivid fear, sharp enough to jolt my mind fully awake, swept over me. This couldn't be an ordinary nightmare. It couldn't be.

At the same time, a horrifying sense of incongruity enveloped me.

This feeling… Why do I know it?

When had I felt it? Where? I searched through memories I didn't want to revisit, and my whole body began to tremble.

Flash!

A blinding light burst forth from somewhere.

The red gaze and the ominous, clammy presence around it broke apart. So did the darkness that had swallowed everything. The chill vanished.

Warmth wrapped around my body. I reached toward the light now right in front of me.

Grab!

…Huh?

Thoughts raced through my head.

Why could I grab the light? Why did it feel so good? I had definitely woken up from the dream, so why could I still feel it?

Rub, rub.

What the hell was this?

After thinking for a moment, I opened my eyes, which I had closed slightly.

The bright light was someone's smooth, shiny head.

A Buddhist precept seal marked his forehead.

"Krillin?"[2438]

The monk, whom I had never seen before—not Krillin—opened his mouth with an awkward expression.

"You have finally awakened, Benefactor Jin."

"Excuse me, but who…?"

"This humble monk is Jung Ho."

Who was Jung Ho?

After a moment's thought, I asked haltingly, my voice thick with sleep.

[2438] Krillin is a bald martial artist from *Dragon Ball*.

"Were you perhaps Park Jung Ho from Class 6, Grade 3 at Garam Middle School…?"

"Pardon?"

"When did you become a monk?"

"A good forty years, at least… No, wait. Could you please listen to me, Benefactor?"

"Oh, right, you bastard. Didn't you say you were going to become a priest? When did you switch? Apostate. Apostate. Did the Full Gospel Church[2439] Crusaders beat you up? Look how much your face has aged. Which temple hired you?"

My old classmate answered with a half-resigned expression.

"…I am the Discipline Hall Master at Shaolin."

"Shaolin?"

"Yes. Shaolin Temple."

"Wait. If you're at Shaolin Temple…"

Oh. Fuck. What?

Only then did my mind fully clear. I hurriedly shook my head to dispel the sleep and cautiously opened my mouth.

"Ah, I'm sorry. I wasn't fully awake."

"I understand."

Jung Ho, the middle-aged monk, looked as though he understood nothing of the sort. He continued.

"Could you take your hand off my head now? You've been touching it this whole time…"

"Whoops. Sorry."

"It's all right."

His expression said otherwise. He plainly wanted to give me a piece of his mind, but he seemed to be holding back because of the help I'd given him.

Why was Shaolin's Discipline Hall Master beside me when I woke up, anyway?

Only then did it strike me as strange. I looked around to get my bearings.

The room was big enough to sleep ten people. Sunlight came through a half-open window and gleamed off Jung Ho's forehead. As for the familiar faces…

They were sprawled all around me.

So it was a dream, but half of it was real.

No wonder it had felt so vivid.

I let out a deep sigh, then first kicked the lump curled up asleep at my feet.

Thump!

"Ah! Meat dumplings for lunch today!"

"…"

What kind of wake-up cry was that?

[2439] Full Gospel Church refers to a Korean Pentecostal Protestant church.

Cheongpung sprang awake from the sudden impact and opened his sleepy eyes.

“Ah, Benefactor. Did you sleep well?”

“I slept. I wouldn’t call it well.”

“Why not? Then sleep some more.”

“…Are you kidding me? Stop talking nonsense and get this thing off me.”

“Oh! Mimi! Come here!”

Cheongpung finally noticed the pet snake coiled around my neck. At his call, its thick body slid down across my chest.

Wait. Thick?

I stared open-mouthed at the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, which looked practically like a python now.

“Cheongpung. Was it always that big?”

“No. It has grown a lot lately. It’s right in the middle of its growth period.”

“How old is it?”

“Grandpa Tang says it isn’t even a hundred years old yet.”

“…Oh. I see.”

“It might get bigger than me. Ah, I need to hurry up and grow more too.”

“You’re already grown. Waiting won’t make you any taller.”

“No, I’m not. Mimi keeps getting bigger as she gets older. I’ll keep growing too.”

“…?”

Then shouldn’t Jeok Cheongang and Mungyeong be at least three zhang tall by now?[2440]

I gave Cheongpung a troubled look and gave up trying to convince him. Instead, I smacked the mouth beside me that was giving off a horrific stench.

Smack!

“Urgh!”

“I told you to brush your teeth before bed. You damn beggar, your mouth is a swamp. A goddamn swamp.”

“Guh. Guhhh.”

Gung Gibang woke up and glared at me, his eyes watering.

“Why do you always pick on me?”

“I don’t pick on *only* you. I’m going to deal with this guy the same way.”

People had to be treated equally.

A moment later, Hyuk Mujin, who had been sleeping soundly with one of my legs clutched in his arms, met the same fate.

Whack!

“Argh! Why do you always pick on me?”

[2440] Three zhang, here a traditional Korean measure of length, are approximately 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

"Did you two rehearse that? Or are you brothers separated when you were little?"

"Don't just hit me. Gung Gibang too—oh, he's awake."

"…Hah. You hateful bastards."

I kicked Hyuk Mujin hard enough to send him tumbling beneath the bed while he muttered under his breath.

Because of these idiots, I'd even had a dream when I hardly ever dreamed at all—and an incredibly unsettling nightmare at that.

That gaze.

The red light still sent a chill through me. I was trying to recall that strange feeling from the dream when Jung Ho, who had slipped out during the commotion, came back through the door.

"Benefactor Jin. Could you spare me a moment?"

"Ah, yes."

I sat up straight. After rubbing his head like a bowling ball, I'd have had to make time for him even if I didn't have any.

"Please, speak, Monk."

"My Martial Uncle[2441] wishes to see you, Benefactor."

"Your Martial Uncle? Is he the person waiting outside?"

"Yes. He says he would like to speak with you again after so long…"

So that was it. I'd wondered why I could sense two presences.

Jung Ho's Martial Uncle had to be a senior monk of Shaolin. But someone who wanted to speak with me *again*?

Who is it? The way he put it, we've definitely met before.

Besides the Dharma King, was there anyone at Shaolin with whom I had formed that kind of connection?

I nodded readily enough.

"Of course."

No sooner had I spoken than someone came through the door. I frowned.

"Excuse me, but who…?"

He had a slender build, and every inch of exposed skin was covered in scars. A rough voice came from the lips of the fierce-looking monk I had never seen before.

"I'm glad. Though the heavens have grown dim, the Morning Star that rose in the north seems to shine even brighter."

"…!"

"How have you been, Benefactor?"

Only then did I recognize the monk before me. His appearance and the air about him had changed so much that it had taken me a moment to find his name.

[2441] Martial Uncle is a title for someone of one's teacher's generation within a martial or monastic lineage, not necessarily a relative.

“Unnamed.”

Chapter 517

“Have you been well, Benefactor?”

I almost didn’t recognize him. Unnamed had changed that much since I’d met him a year ago. His face, his manner of speaking, the air about him—everything felt unfamiliar.

And the reason he’d changed was probably…

It must be because of what happened that day, three months ago.

What was I supposed to say? I had a bitter taste in my mouth. I waited until Jung Ho and Hyuk Mujin had taken the others out of the room before I spoke.

“I haven’t been doing all that well myself. More has happened than I expected.”

Unnamed smiled faintly.

“So it seems. In fact, I only learned what had happened to you two days ago.”

No martial artist could have missed the events of the past three months. If Unnamed, who held an important position at Shaolin, had heard about them only two days ago, I could think of just one reason.

“You were in closed-door training.”

“Amitabha.[2442] I was staying in Repentance Cave.”

“Repentance Cave? Does that mean…”

“What you’re thinking is correct. I asked to go there myself, so please don’t worry.”

The first character meant shame; the second, remorse. Repentance Cave was a place where sinners were confined.

What was he ashamed of? What did he feel he had to repent for? Perhaps it was his regret at failing to prevent his Master’s death. Unnamed had spent three months there, calling himself a sinner for failing to protect even the Green Jade Buddha Staff, the divine artifact of Shaolin his Master had entrusted to him before he died.

“In the darkness, where I couldn’t see an inch in front of me, I kept thinking.”

Unnamed ran a callused finger over his cheek. Much of his scar-covered face had turned a dark bluish-black.

It was the mark left by the Yin-Cold Qi of the enemy he had risked his life to stop three months ago. A burden he would never be free of.

“If only I’d been a little stronger, I might have protected my Master. I might have carried out his final request.”

But regret always came too late. A venerable monk respected by all had died unexpectedly. Someone had lost a close friend. And someone else, consumed by guilt at failing to carry out his Master’s final wishes, had gone into Repentance Cave.

[2442] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

Anyone would have felt the same.

I was no different. I didn't even want to imagine how I would have felt if I'd failed to save Jeok Cheongang and had to let him go. Maybe I would have gone back to being F-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung, trapped in that same cycle of regret and despair.

But pain changes people, for better or worse. In Unnamed's case, it had changed him for the better. His heart might have been broken, but at least his martial arts had grown stronger.

"This is just my opinion, but I doubt you spent all your time in Repentance Cave thinking."

"Amitabha.[2443] I owe it all to the grace of the Buddha and Shaolin."

Unnamed pressed his palms together toward the sunlit window, then looked at me with calm eyes. There was a pure power in his gaze. A year ago, his body had been packed with solid muscle. Now he was as lean as an old tree. But the quiet aura flowing from him was on another level from before.

He's broken through.

He had entered the supreme realm every martial artist dreamed of reaching. There was no doubt about it.

Seeing the awe in my eyes, Unnamed gave a small nod.

"Enlightenment alone wasn't enough to heal a body in critical condition and reach a higher realm. I needed many other things. The Great Restoration Pill was one of them."

"Ah."

Shaolin's Great Restoration Pill was among the finest elixirs in the world.

Right. With the Great Restoration Pill, it might have been possible.

The pill's effects were one thing, but Unnamed was the Disciple whom Dharma King Hong Dao, a man capable of reading heavenly patterns, had personally brought in and raised with all his heart. He was a genius born with tremendous martial talent—not quite on Cheongpung's level, perhaps, but still extraordinary. There was no doubt that he was worthy of the Great Restoration Pill.

He had reached the Supreme Peak realm while still in his thirties. That proved both his Master's eye for talent and his own ability.

"Congratulations. I've heard the Great Restoration Pill is precious even by Shaolin's standards."

"That's why I refused it so firmly. But my Senior Brother, the Abbot, gave it to me and told me not to ask questions. Apparently, my Master had said something to him about it several years ago. Perhaps… he knew this would happen."

[2443] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

A faint smile touched Unnamed's lips. He gazed into the distance for a moment, as though remembering his Master, then went on.

"Oh, my Senior Brother Abbot would also like to meet Benefactor Jin."

"Your Senior Brother Abbot?"

I hadn't heard who had succeeded Dharma King Hong Dao. Gung Gibang had said it would be one of the Dharma King's direct Disciples, but one spectacular disaster after another had kept me too busy to think about it.

"I don't believe you've met him. He's my eldest Senior Brother in our lineage, and he became Abbot less than a month ago. It's only natural that you wouldn't know him."

"Ah, I see."

"He said he was sorry things had been so chaotic last time that he let you leave without even saying goodbye."

"He doesn't need to apologize. I was barely thinking straight myself."

The Shaolin Bloodshed during the Star-Array Grand Banquet had been unprecedented, but I'd had to leave Henan for Sichuan within a day or two. Jeok Cheongang was in critical condition, and finding the Divine Physician couldn't wait.

"Amitabha.[2444] I was truly glad when I finally heard that Benefactor Jeok had made a full recovery. My Master must be watching over me from somewhere. I'm sure he was relieved to see his friend well again."

"Ah, speaking of which, you must have met the Old— No, my Master already."

"We spoke until you woke up. I nearly failed to recognize him at first."

"Well, he has, uh… changed a little."

"Yes. About as much as I have."

"…Uh."

What was I supposed to say to that?

While I hesitated over his sudden self-deprecating joke, Unnamed politely pressed his palms together.

"Amitabha.[2445] That was a joke."

"Oh. Ah. Right."

"You didn't find it amusing. I'll refrain from making another."

Please do rose to the tip of my tongue.

A joke like that was funny coming from someone who hadn't suffered quite so much. Coming from Unnamed, it made the whole room turn solemn. But I didn't have the courage to nod.

"…No, it was funny."

[2444] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

[2445] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

"Amitabha.[2446] Then I'll continue."

"…"

"That was the joke."

Should I just crack his head open with a wooden fish?[2447]

I stared at him, dumbfounded, then let out a quiet laugh. If he could make clumsy jokes like these, he'd come through it better than I'd feared.

I might not be able to comfort him, but I could at least listen to a few temple jokes that pushed the limits.

Anyway…

"Where are we? This doesn't look like Shaolin Temple."

Judging by the sun outside, I'd slept for about a full day, but I still had no idea where we were. I looked around again, and Unnamed explained.

"An inn near Mount Song. It's been rented in the name of the Murim Alliance, so please stay and rest as long as you need."

"The Murim Alliance."

The name had always felt distant. Hearing Unnamed say it here in Henan made it suddenly real. I got out of bed and went to the window.

The first thing I saw was a peak of Mount Song rising in the distance as though it might pierce the sky. Buildings crowded the foot of the mountain, and all sorts of people filled the streets.

One martial artist had a narrow-bladed sword at his waist. Another carried a massive saber on his back without a scabbard. Others bore spears and twin axes…

"…"

All sorts of people, sure. But something was off.

They're scary.

Unnamed gave a low laugh as I watched the martial artists everywhere I looked.

"Amitabha.[2448] They've come from all across the land after hearing the news."

"Even at a glance, there seem to be more of them than there were at the Star-Array Grand Banquet."

"The Star-Array Grand Banquet was a festival for young prodigies. The founding of the Murim Alliance concerns everyone. People from both the orthodox and unorthodox factions are here, and quite a few little-known eccentrics have come out of seclusion as well."

That made sense. The stakes were entirely different, so of course more people had come. If the Star-Array Grand Banquet was the Han River fireworks festival, the

[2446] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

[2447] A wooden fish is a carved wooden percussion instrument struck to keep rhythm during Buddhist chanting.

[2448] Amitabha is the name of a Buddha, used here as a Buddhist invocation.

founding of the Murim Alliance was Jindotgae One.[2449] Unlike at the banquet, there were hardly any commoners in sight.

They can feel it too. They know what's happening here.

As I thought that to myself, a group of Murim practitioners crossing the main road suddenly caught my eye. Their aura was unusual enough that they could not be mistaken for ordinary martial artists. They clearly belonged to one of the great prestigious factions.

Their clothes are strange, too. Who are they?

I didn't need to ask Unnamed. Wrapped in furs despite the warm spring day and wearing leather armor unlike the other martial artists, they drew whispers wherever they went.

"Could they be…?"

"That's right. The Murong Family."

"My word. It's well over a thousand li[2450] from Liaoning to Henan. They got here quickly."

"They're said to have the blood of horse-riding nomads for a reason. What luck. I never thought I'd see members of the Murong Family in my lifetime."

It was my first time seeing the Murong Family, too. Shanxi Province, where the Jin Family of Taiyuan was located, was also considered a frontier region, but Liaoning lay far to the northeast beyond Hebei. It was not somewhere one could visit as casually as the neighborhood next door.

It was so far away that I'd heard members of the Murong Family rarely came to the Central Plains.

So that's the Murong Family.

They were among the stronger of the Five Great Families, and I'd heard of their reputation until I was sick of it. Unlike other factions, they even maintained a cavalry unit, or so I'd been told. Maybe that was why every one of them had muscles like a horse.

The orthodox Murim, led by the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families. It sounds like the unorthodox Murim has joined in, too. And on top of that, all the martial artists who belong nowhere at all…

People often called the United States a melting pot of races. Right now, Henan looked exactly like that to me. Granted, the people here were of the same or similar races, but every kind of martial artist I'd seldom get to see had gathered in one place.

Three days.

[2449] Jindotgae One is South Korea's highest military alert level, used when an enemy attack is considered imminent.

[2450] A Chinese li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

Three days from now, countless martial artists would gather beneath a single banner. United under the name of the Murim Alliance, they would raise their weapons and stand against Dark Heaven.

I was looking out at them and thinking just that when—

Boom!

A tremendous roar sounded from somewhere.

Chapter 518

A middle-aged man, thoroughly drunk, suddenly raised one hand.

“Innkeeper, bring me a bottle of strong liquor!”

“Roast duck, too!”

“Would you look at these petty-minded fools. We’re on the verge of a momentous event—the founding of the Murim Alliance—and you want strong liquor and roast duck? We’ve come to Henan, so we should at least drink Dukang wine[2451]!”

“Oh, we’d love that, but aren’t you pushing yourself too far?”

“It’s fine. We’re splitting the bill anyway.”

“…You’ve lost your mind. Make it strong liquor.”

The inn on the main road near Mount Song was packed. Most of the people inside were Murim practitioners, of course.

From wandering martial artists who still looked like greenhorns to old veterans who had roamed the martial world for ten years—or even several decades.

The people gathered there differed in purpose, age, and gender.

Wherever people gathered, conflict was bound to follow. Especially when the people in question were drunk Murim practitioners.

“Wait. You’re…!”

“Oh-ho. Aren’t you the Senior Disciple of the Xiao He Gate? Still missing that finger?”

“You bastard! You came looking for a place to die!”

The world might be vast, but enemies had a way of meeting even on a single-plank bridge.

When people bound by tangled webs of gratitude and grudges happened to meet, blades were sure to come out.

Clang! Slash!

Sharp weapons swung, and blood sprayed through the air. The fierce exchange sent the surrounding Murim practitioners into an uproar.

“Waaah!”

“It’s a fight!”

“One silver nyang[2452] on the Senior Disciple of the Xiao He Gate!”

“Then I’ll bet two nyang[2453] on the Long Serpent Saber!”

They said nothing was more entertaining than watching someone else’s house burn or watching someone else fight.

[2451] Dukang is a traditional Chinese liquor named for Du Kang, a legendary figure associated with winemaking. It is particularly associated with Henan.

[2452] A nyang is a traditional unit used for silver currency; it is not Korean won.

[2453] A nyang is a traditional unit used for silver currency; it is not Korean won.

The very few people with no connection to Murim backed away with horrified expressions. But the Murim practitioners, who were crazy about fighting regardless of whether it involved the orthodox, unorthodox, or Demonic Path, shouted and applauded without hesitation.

Amid the chaos, almost no one noticed the middle-aged man who had just come through the inn's old door.

Clang! Bang!

Waaah!

The fight was raging in the middle of the inn, but he did not spare it a glance. He flicked a silver nyang[2454] toward the innkeeper.

"Two bottles of strong liquor and one roast duck. Bring them to a seat with a good view outside. Oh, and roast the duck until it's crisp."

"Great Hero…"

"Hm?"

The innkeeper bowed to him.

"I'm sorry, but there aren't any suitable seats available right now."

"There aren't?"

"No, Great Hero. As you can see, so many heroes of Murim have come to visit…"

The middle-aged man looked around, then glanced up. Several faces were peering down from above the stairs.

"There seem to be seats up there."

"Ah, I'm terribly sorry, but there are other guests on that floor—"

"That one looks good."

"W-wait a moment, Great Hero! Great Hero!"

The middle-aged man ignored the innkeeper's desperate cries.

He strode up the stairs, ignoring the sharp gazes that poured down on him, and muttered,

"Much better. Quiet, too."

The inn's second floor was reserved for people of higher status.

It was only about twenty steps above the first floor, but unlike the noisy chaos below, a serious atmosphere hung over the second floor. Nor were the people seated at its tables anything like Third Rate martial artists.

"G-Great Hero! You can't go up there!"

At the innkeeper's cry from behind him, the low conversations stopped.

A graying middle-aged man seated at the table closest to the stairs frowned and spoke.

"What's all this noise?"

[2454] A nyang is a traditional unit used for silver currency; it is not Korean won.

"I-I'm sorry, Great Hero. This gentleman seems to have mistaken where he was going—"

"Send him downstairs. And quiet the first floor while you're at it."

"Yes, sir."

But the middle-aged man was already headed elsewhere.

"That seat by the window looks good."

"Gasp, Great Hero!"

The one who stepped forward in place of the horrified innkeeper was the graying middle-aged man from before.

"Stop."

The middle-aged man slowly turned.

"Was that directed at me?"

"Who else would I be speaking to?"

"You?"

"You look a great deal younger than I am, so don't cause unnecessary trouble. Go back downstairs."

The graying man added with an air of dignity, "Since you don't seem to know much about the martial world, I'll tell you who I am. I'm of the Fang Family. In the martial world, I'm known as Moon Beauty Saber."

"Oh."

"Now that you know, stop making a scene and go downstairs quietly."

The middle-aged man blinked a few times.

"What you just said—was it really true?"

Moon Beauty Saber gave a short laugh.

Who was he? He was a top-tier wandering martial artist who had long since reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy.

He was on an entirely different level from wandering martial artists like Blood Cudgel, who strutted around despite being merely at the early Peak realm.

"Heh heh. Why would I lie? Then again, I suppose it's understandable that you don't believe me. You probably never expected to meet me in a place like this."

"No, not that. I meant, do I really look that way?"

"…?"

What was this man talking about?

Moon Beauty Saber stared at him blankly, then frowned.

"What do you mean? I don't understand you at all."

"You said I looked young. That was certainly true, wasn't it?"

"…!"

"Hm. That's rather nice to hear. Good. I understand."

Before Moon Beauty Saber could reply, the middle-aged man laughed heartily and pointed toward the window.

“Don’t mind me. Keep drinking. I happen to know someone.”

“Why, you bastard…”

“Great Hero!”

Moon Beauty Saber and the innkeeper spoke at once. Then the old man drinking alone by the window suddenly cut in.

“I was feeling lonely drinking by myself, so this is perfect. Come, sit.”

“…!”

“…!”

The innkeeper and Moon Beauty Saber both fell silent.

The innkeeper could hardly object when the guest himself had invited the man over. Moon Beauty Saber hesitated for a different reason. Something about the old man’s manner had been bothering him since earlier.

He looks like a wealthy old man, but there’s something unusual about him… How does he know that ignorant fool?

Moon Beauty Saber wanted to teach the middle-aged man a lesson right then and there, but he couldn’t shake his unease.

Whether he knew what Moon Beauty Saber was thinking or not, the middle-aged man dropped into the seat across from the old man and immediately tilted back a bottle.

“Ah, that’s good. Is this Yeoahong[2455]?”

The old man nodded.

“The innkeeper said it had been aged at least twenty years.”

“Good wine. But strong liquor is still the best there is. The innkeeper will bring some soon. You should try it.”

“I’ll pass. I don’t usually drink much.”

“What a shame. Why are you here alone, then?”

“It’s nothing. I simply thought I would try burying myself among other people after such a long time.”

The old man suddenly turned his head and gazed out the window.

For a while, he watched the people passing through the street and listened to the bustle outside. Then he said, “Now that I’m here, being alone like this isn’t so bad.”

“You don’t seem to have come alone.”

“I have children and grandchildren, of course. Just as you have a Disciple.”

“I do have one fellow, though I’m not sure whether he’s my Disciple or my enemy. How did you know?”

[2455]Yeoahong is a traditional Chinese rice wine. Its name means “Daughter’s Red.”

“How could I not? I even saw him myself.”

Clack.

The middle-aged man set down the bottle. Liquor had spilled from the corner of his mouth, dampening his beard. Perhaps because of the soft light, the beard looked unusually red.

“Damn it. I knew it. But that brat kept insisting to the very end that he’d never met you.”

“You certainly raised your Disciple well, Fire King.”

The middle-aged man wiped his beard with his sleeve, then stared at the old man.

“My Disciple caused you trouble last time. So I came to see you myself, Azure Sky Sword King.”

The old man—no, the Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family and one of the Ten Kings, the Azure Sky Sword King—smiled faintly.

“I’m glad to hear it.”

“I knew you, of all people, would recognize this old man.”

“I almost didn’t. Returned to Youth… You were worth waiting for.”

“It’s late, but may I keep the promise I made back then?”

“I’ve waited a very long time to hear you say that.”

Joy filled the Azure Sky Sword King’s eyes.

More than twenty years ago, in exchange for entrusting one person’s life to Jeok Cheongang, he had been promised a duel.

At last, his long wait was over.

“What a shame. The strong liquor will be here soon.”

“Let whoever’s left standing drink it.”

“And your sword? Will you be all right without one?”

“My sword?”

The Azure Sky Sword King picked up the two chopsticks laid neatly on the table.

“These will do.”

Jeok Cheongang gave a short laugh and looked out the window.

“The sky is blue, and you have a sword in your hand.”

“The sun is up as well. Perfect timing.”

Whoooosh.

Wind swept through the room. Invisible waves of qi surged from the two men and spread in every direction.

And before anyone in the inn could notice, the two supreme masters struck at each other.

KABOOM!

Bang! Bang! KABOOM!

“Good Lord.”

What in tarnation is that?

I gaped at the scene in the distance beyond the window.

And it wasn’t just the successive booms or the black smoke rising into the sky.

Unnamed, who realized it a moment after I did, spoke with a hardened expression.

“Did you feel it too, Benefactor?”

I gave a small nod.

Even at this distance, I could feel waves of qi reaching us. *This is a clash between at least Supreme Peak masters.*

“If something like this has happened, then it must be…”

“Amitabha[2456]. Yes. It appears Dark Heaven is attacking.”

“Those Dark Heaven sons of bitches!”

“Though we took every precaution, this has happened again. Given that, this humble monk will have no choice but to break the precept against killing and go all out against them.”

“I’ll join you. Breaking the no-killing precept against Dark Heaven is a hobby of mine.”

And it seemed I wasn’t the only one with that hobby.

Ding. Diiing!

“Dark Heaven! Dark Heaven is attacking!”

“Kill them and uphold justice!”

“Beat those wicked fiends to death!”

Alarm bells rang out, and the Murim practitioners on the main road rushed toward the disturbance like a pack of dogs.

The sight made my blood boil.

Ah, so this is the Murim Crusade.

Our side is fucking strong. And there are a hell of a lot of us.

Until now, I had suffered every kind of hell against Dark Heaven because of our numerical disadvantage—or simply because of the gap in strength.

I could almost cry.

I can’t sit this one out.

“Follow me! Follow me!”

I leaped out the window and stood tall. The people who spotted me widened their eyes.

[2456] Amitabha is the Buddha of Infinite Light. Saying his name is a Buddhist invocation.

“The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

“It’s the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan!”

“Oooooh!”

Believe it or not, I was a pretty big name in Murim.

Living proof that even a cramped backwater like Shanxi Province could produce a dragon! A young icon of the orthodox faction!

“Waaah!”

“Let’s go! Let’s sweep Dark Heaven away!”

“The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon is with us!”

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

The Murim practitioners charged forward with renewed courage, shouting as they ran.

Unnamed and I were at the very front, of course.

“Fuck! Wreck ‘em all!”

I poured my internal energy into the shout, and the roar around me swelled.

With this many Murim practitioners at my side, I was sure we could beat the hell out of anyone.

“It’s a holy war!”

“Great Hero Jin says it’s a holy war!”

“Kill those demons!”

“Amitabhaaa[2457]!”

You Dark Heaven bastards! Stay right there! I’m bringing the Murim Crusade to you, and I’m going to bash your heads in. Your heads…

“Ah.”

My brain suddenly stopped working.

A single person was walking out from inside a building burning horribly.

“What the hell are you all doing?”

“…”

The fiend was on our side.

[2457] Amitabha is the Buddha of Infinite Light. Saying his name is a Buddhist invocation.

Chapter 519

KABOOM!

A large inn burned fiercely. Blackened wooden pillars collapsed, sending ash billowing into the air. The face of the fiend who emerged through it all was so familiar it came as a shock.

“What the hell are you all doing?”

“…”

That’s what I wanted to ask.

Silence fell. Unnamed stared at me, his gaze shaking as though an earthquake had struck. Sound Transmission slipped through his barely moving lips and reached my ears.

Why—why is Benefactor Jeok coming out of there?

How should I know?

Wasn’t he Dark Heaven?

That’s what I want to ask.

Amitabha[2458]*. Could you be Dark Heaven?*

What kind of crazy question is that?

If we’re Dark Heaven, does that make you a member of the Vatican?

I wasn’t the only one dumbfounded by Unnamed’s words. Jeok Cheongang, who was exceptionally skilled at eavesdropping on Sound Transmission, already had a face twisted like an evil spirit.

“What? This old man is Dark Heaven?”

“N-no, that’s not what I meant. There’s been a small misunderstanding…”

My attempt to clear up that misunderstanding went nowhere. More precisely, our proud Murim Crusade—already burning with fighting spirit ahead of the Murim Alliance’s founding—wouldn’t let it.

“Dark Heaven!”

“The fiend just declared himself Dark Heaven!”

Keyword entered.

“Wait. He seems to know the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.”

“Of course he knows him! How many times has the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon fought Dark Heaven?”

“I see. He’s a Dark Heaven fiend!”

Miraculous logic.

“You fiend! You look like a demon straight out of hell!”

“And that hair, all bright red! He looks like he’ll dye the world in blood!”

[2458] *Amitabha* is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

Attacking his appearance.

"Kill him first!"

"Capture him and you'll become a hero!"

Medieval Crusader-style conclusion.

All of this happened in the blink of an eye. Faced with the collective madness of some thousand Murim Crusaders, Unnamed and I snapped out of our daze and waved our hands frantically.

"No! That's not it!"

"Amitabha[2459]! Everyone, stop! That man is my master, Master Hong Dao's…"

At Unnamed's shout, the martial artists nearest us widened their eyes.

"Oh!"

"Is that true?"

Finally. They're listening.

Unnamed glanced at me as if he thought the same thing, then nodded.

"It is."

"Good heavens. Not just any fiend, but the villain who harmed Master Hong Dao!"

"What?"

"What an unforgivable fiend! Tear him limb from limb!"

"…"

Fuck. I can't do this.

Would these martial artists suffer qi deviation if they listened to someone finish a sentence? They refused to understand a damn word.

The grand finale of this collective madness came courtesy of a stranger emerging from the wreckage of the collapsed building.

"Stop, you wicked fiend! How dare you commit such a heinous crime in Henan!"

Jeok Cheongang, who had been staring at this insanity with his mouth open, muttered with a pained expression.

"Not one of these people is in his right mind. Listen to this old man first…"

"Enough talk! This Moon Beauty Saber will not forgive you!"

"…Then you can take a beating first."

Fair enough. For Jeok Cheongang, he'd held back a long time.

Whoosh. Fwoom!

Bye-bye, Moon Beauty Saber. Enjoy the Disco Pang Pang.[2460]

Moon Beauty Saber rushed forward like a streak of light, then shot backward like a cannonball and slammed deep into the wreckage.

[2459] *Amitabha* is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

[2460] Disco Pang Pang is a Korean amusement ride that spins and jolts its riders.

None of the martial artists gathered there had seen the punch. None of them could have. The sheer force of it froze the air around them.

"M-Moon Beauty Saber, down in a single blow…!"

"Aaah! The fiend's martial arts have reached the heavens!"

Forget his martial arts. His anger looks like it's reached the heavens.

Everyone seemed to understand that provoking Jeok Cheongang right now would be a bad idea. They wanted to defeat a fiend and make a name for themselves, sure. They just didn't want to be the ones getting defeated.

Finally, some quiet.

With everyone silent, I had one chance to clear up the misunderstanding. I cleared my throat and opened my mouth.

Or rather, I was about to.

"There's been a serious misunderstanding. The man over there isn't a fiend, he's __"

"Halt! Make way!"

"Oh, for fuck's sake!"

I'm going to lose my mind. Who is it this time?

But the man who appeared as the crowd parted like the Red Sea was not someone I could simply call a bastard.

"The Thunderbolt Saber King has arrived!"

"Great Hero Peng has come to punish the fiend himself!"

Thud. Thud.

An enormous old man strode forward as the crowd's courage surged anew. He had broad shoulders, fierce eyes, and a massive saber slung over one shoulder.

At the sight of the Thunderbolt Saber King, Jeok Cheongang sighed.

"Finally, someone I can talk to."

Agreed.

The Thunderbolt Saber King and Jeok Cheongang bickered constantly, but they were quite close. Longtime rivals who were, for all practical purposes, friends. He would recognize Jeok without any trouble.

Sure enough, the Thunderbolt Saber King looked him up and down, then opened his eyes wide.

"What are you doing here?"

"It's a long story. Send these people away first."

"Answer my question first."

"Hm?"

"I asked what a bastard fiend who deserves to be torn limb from limb is doing here."

"…"

"…"

Jeok Cheongang's eyelids began to twitch.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

Hooves sounded through the silence. The enormous old man gazing out of the carriage window suddenly spoke.

"The truth is, I recognized you the moment I saw you. How could I not?"

With everyone watching, the Thunderbolt Saber King continued in a solemn voice.

"Red hair, red beard. Anyone would know you were the Fire King. The others couldn't have dreamed you'd Returned to Youth, but I knew."

"I see."

I nodded, then asked, "So why did you start swinging your saber?"

"That was…"

"Oh, and while you're at it, explain why you ordered an all-out attack after one exchange left you shaking in your boots."

"Shaking in my boots? Ha ha ha."

A heavy silence settled over the carriage. Faced with everyone's distrustful stares, the Thunderbolt Saber King stiffened.

"I wanted to give them some real combat experience."

"Ah. Combat experience."

"Think of it as preparation for the coming fight against Dark Heaven. Facing the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, would be valuable experience for all of them."

I asked seriously,

"By 'experience,' do you mean experience of the afterlife?"

"…"

That shut him up. If he had a conscience, it had to: twenty people had been carried to the medical clinic. Most were Third Rate martial artists caught in the aftermath of blows exchanged between two of the Ten Kings—the Fire King and the Thunderbolt Saber King.

We're lucky it stopped there.

If the poet Yun Dong-ju[2461] suffered at even the wind stirring a leaf, they suffered like hell in the howling blade wind.

"Still… I heard they're all safe."

"They are. They'll be safe for at least the next fifteen days, since they'll spend them lying in the medical clinic."

[2461] Yun Dong-ju was a Korean poet of the Japanese colonial period, known for poetry marked by intense sensitivity and introspection.

Their taste of the afterlife had left its mark.

Martial artists might live on the edge of a blade, but PTSD was no joke. I'd visited the victims. Their faces were pale, and they couldn't even speak.

The worst of all was the wandering martial artist called Moon Beauty Saber. He was trembling so violently that I almost mistook Henan for Antarctica's King Sejong Station.[2462]

"None of this would have happened if you hadn't ordered that all-out attack, Great Hero Peng."

The Thunderbolt Saber King's round eyes widened at my continued criticism.

"And what about you?"

"Me?"

"Yes, you! Weren't you the one who rounded up every martial artist nearby and brought them here?"

"I admit that part. But given the circumstances, it was unavoidable. Isn't that right?"

At my question, Unnamed, my accomplice in the corner, ran his fingers over his prayer beads.

"Benefactor Jin is correct. Even if Shakyamuni[2463] had been in my position, he would have rushed forward crying out for the destruction of demons."

"Could you uproot a bodhi tree[2464] and crush a fiend's skull with it?"

"Amitabha[2465]. I could."

"…"

The Thunderbolt Saber King had a temper to match Jeok Cheongang's, but he couldn't openly pick on Unnamed. The only Disciple left behind by his dear friend, the Dharma King Hong Dao, was a sore spot for him.

"Urgh."

He glared at me.

"And you've been at it this whole time!"

"What? Why?"

"Are you and I friends?"

"No."

"Then do you think the Hebei Peng Family is a joke?"

"How did you get from one to the other? You're changing the subject because you've run out of things to say."

[2462] King Sejong Station is a South Korean research station in Antarctica.

[2463] Shakyamuni is the historical Buddha.

[2464] The bodhi tree is the tree under which the Buddha is said to have attained enlightenment.

[2465] *Amitabha* is the name of a Buddha, spoken here as a Buddhist invocation.

"You little brat. The blood on your head hasn't even dried, and you keep talking back…"

"Oof. Clack, clack. Dentures."

I didn't know exactly what dentures had to do with anything, but the feeling behind it clearly got through.

"How dare you!"

The Thunderbolt Saber King's face flushed red. He was about to leap to his feet when the two men who had been silent all along spoke almost at once.

"Calm yourself, Sir Peng."

"Quiet. All of you, shut your mouths."

The voices and moods could hardly have been more different. Perhaps the only thing connecting the two men was the two characters in their title: Ten Kings.

"I was rash," the Azure Sky Sword King said plainly. "It had been so long since I last felt my blood stir. I let it get the better of me."

Jeok Cheongang spoke next.

"This old man did nothing wrong. You were the rash ones."

"…"

That's our Old Master.

An evergreen if ever there was one. The Thunderbolt Saber King stared at Jeok as if wondering whether he was human.

"Jeok, don't you feel even a little guilty?"

"Why should I? Martial artists can have a little scrap when they meet. There were people fighting in the inn before I even went in."

"What would have happened if Great Hero Namgung hadn't stepped in when he did?"

The Thunderbolt Saber King was right about that much. The dove of peace who'd brought the situation under control was the Azure Sky Sword King.

After a brief exchange with Jeok Cheongang, he'd suffered a minor Internal Injury. He appeared only after settling his internal energy, and one of the Namgung Family members among the crowd recognized him.

Whoa, whoa, whoaaa! Grand Family Head!

He'd screamed like he'd seen a ghost.

The other martial artists, who'd lost their heads at the words *Dark Heaven*, finally came to their senses. One lunatic did ask whether the Namgung Family was part of Dark Heaven too, but fortunately, our proud Murim Crusaders regained their reason.

If Jeok Cheongang hadn't Returned to Youth, a few of them probably would have recognized him in the first place.

"That was almost a catastrophe!"

"I could have explained everything. And it happened because your eyes are as bad as a dog's, you Peng bastard."

"The inn collapsed! People got hurt!"

"Ahem."

Perhaps he felt a bit guilty himself. Jeok Cheongang cleared his throat, then opened his mouth with a shameless expression.

"Given the location, I held back. At worst, they got bumped by a little falling debris. Put some spit on it and they'll be fine. I'll compensate the innkeeper properly. Even I could see the place burned quite badly."

"…Is that really coming from the man who killed a thousand members of the Demonic Cult for burning Mount Jiuhua? The more I hear, the more my chest swells."

"Of course they had to die. Those bastards never intended to pay compensation."

"…"

What is this?

It was utter nonsense, yet somehow it had a logic of its own.

Momentarily at a loss for words, the Thunderbolt Saber King muttered,

"Returned to Youth only changed the skin you're wearing. The contents are still the same. Your personality is still completely fucked."

"You ought to do something about the skin on your face, Peng. All you've done is get old without Returning to Youth."

"What did you say?"

"Ho. They say a man who failed to Return to Youth gets angry when reminded of it. You're a perfect example."

"How dare you, Jeok!"

"Hm? What did you say? I can't hear you. The words of an insignificant nobody who couldn't even Return to Youth are hard to make out."

Would you look at him dishing out area-of-effect damage.

I couldn't speak for anyone else, but I saw the Azure Sky Sword King's shoulders twitch in his seat by the window. He quietly avoided my gaze, looked outside, and spoke.

"You two should stop now."

At first I thought he was only trying to change the subject. Then I followed his gaze.

"Yeah. You definitely should."

Ahead of us stood a long stretch of city wall and a vast crowd. Above the iron gates, a huge sign bore three characters in bold, soaring strokes.

Murim Alliance.

Chapter 520

The young man gazed blankly out the window.

It was a beautiful spring day. The sunlight was just right, and the breeze through the half-open window was pleasantly cool. Flowers had come into full bloom, filling the air with their sweet fragrance.

It was a Wuling Peach Blossom Spring[2466] in the mortal world.

Everything would have been perfect if a voice had not suddenly spoken behind him.

“It’s a beautiful day.”

The young man was not startled. He had sensed someone approaching long before they spoke.

Nor was it only this visitor he could sense.

In front of him, behind him, to either side. Above and below.

He perceived everything happening around him and took it all in. He did not do it out of necessity or by conscious effort. It came as naturally as breathing.

What a shame. I can’t even enjoy the spring scenery properly anymore.

The young man turned. An old man with the imposing bearing of someone much younger stood smiling at him.

“I stopped by out of an old man’s needless concern, only to find you slacking off.”

His voice carried the weight of his years. His tone was gentle, like a grandfather speaking to a young grandson, but experience had taught the young man what lay beneath it.

The old man before him kept a blade hidden—one whose edge was cold and sharp.

“What are you thinking about so intently?”

“Just that I’m fortunate not to be your enemy.”

The old man chuckled softly.

“Anyone overhearing you might think I was a frightening man.”

The young man knew better than to be taken in by that good-natured laugh. No one could say how many schemes and far-reaching plans lay behind that smiling face.

During the upheaval of the Great Faction War, the chief of the Murim Alliance’s Hidden Shadow Pavilion had read the state of the world as though it lay in the palm of his hand and eliminated countless fiends. No man who had done that could be ordinary.

“I doubt anyone else would agree with you, Thousand-Faced Fox.”

Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho.

[2466] The Wuling Peach Blossom Spring is a classical image of an idyllic utopia.

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion's old fox, said to have a thousand faces, shrugged.

"Some people do fear this old man, of course. But I hardly think the man before me is one of them."

"Me?"

"Does it not?"

The young man thought about it for a while. Then his eyes widened.

"Oh. You're right."

"Aren't I?"

"Now that I think about it, I'm not particularly afraid of you."

Had two ordinary Murim practitioners, each willing to stake his life on his pride, exchanged those words, they would have drawn blades by now.

But neither of these men was ordinary. The identity of the man facing Song Ho had much to do with why he took no offense at all.

"Stay alert to everything around you, but fear no one. An Alliance Leader must always do both."

The young man—Sword Saint Mae Jonghak—looked uncomfortable.

"I'd rather you didn't call me Alliance Leader."

"You'll have to accept it sooner or later."

"I simply haven't gotten used to it."

"But you'll soon be Alliance Leader."

"I'm not yet."

"They say it's better to take the whipping early."

"I've always wondered why I have to be the one whipped."

Thousand-Faced Fox's answer was brief.

"Because the Martial God isn't here."

The title *Martial God* had once meant perfection. No, it still did.

Everyone who had met him even once had praised him in unison, and even after the passage of many long years, that vast and brilliant Fame still illuminated the world.

But…

"We couldn't find him."

The Martial God had disappeared. No one knew whether he was alive or dead, or why he had vanished.

Back when the Murim Alliance still existed, Thousand-Faced Fox had cast the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's entire intelligence network across the world. Not one trace of the Martial God had turned up.

Like a moment of sunlight in the middle of a storm. Like a meteor streaking across the night sky.

He had disappeared that way, leaving behind a title that had become the very heavens and still hung over the world.

“With him gone, Great Hero Mae Jonghak, you are the only one who can serve as Alliance Leader.”

“Hah. There must be plenty of suitable candidates besides me.”

“If you mean the other members of the Three Saints and the Ten Kings, I’ll pretend I didn’t hear that.”

“Why?”

“For one thing, no one knows where the Bow Saint is.”

“Isn’t the Hidden Shadow Pavilion still looking for him?”

“Do you think Dark Heaven will wait? Shall I send a messenger pigeon? ‘We’re looking for the Bow Saint. Please hold off for a while’?”

“Oh. When you put it that way.”

“…”

Thousand-Faced Fox held back the urge to bring his fist down on Mae Jonghak’s head and continued.

“And as you know, his personality is somewhat…”

“I liked his fiery spirit.”

“Others won’t be so fond of it if he runs the Murim Alliance into the ground.”

“Hmm. I suppose not.”

“As for the Slaughter Saint… I’d only wear out my mouth explaining.”

“He might be more suitable than you think. His martial arts aside, he had an overwhelming presence. He seemed capable of commanding people.”

“People would follow him, certainly. Anyone who refused would already be dead.”

“Aren’t you treating him too much like the Killing Ghost?”

“His title is *Slaughter Saint*. What do you expect from me?”

“You have a point.”

Should I actually hit him?

Thousand-Faced Fox looked at Mae Jonghak with exactly that thought in his eyes, then sighed.

“The other members of the Ten Kings are unsuitable for much the same reasons. Some have passed away. The rest cannot take the position for one reason or another.”

Strength in martial arts alone did not make an Alliance Leader. The position demanded someone decisive enough to make important choices, and possessed of the character and breadth of mind to bring others together.

In that sense, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was the only possible replacement for the Martial God.

“Great Hero, the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families have given you their approval. You are upright and fair. You show no special favor even to Huashan, your own sect, and you listen to others. You are more than qualified.”

With the rise of the New Murim Alliance, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion had been officially restored, and Thousand-Faced Fox had regained his former standing. But one man’s support could not make an Alliance Leader.

Only someone recognized by all—someone with the qualities of a leader as well as exceptional martial arts—could take that seat.

Not that there were no objections at all.

Thousand-Faced Fox pushed the thought aside and frowned.

“And yet someone like you is leisurely enjoying the spring weather.”

Mae Jonghak glanced wistfully toward the window.

“It was a nice day. I only looked outside for a moment.”

“Do you know how many matters are waiting for you—”

“Oh, right. Take them with you. I put them all together.”

Thousand-Faced Fox stopped in the middle of his scolding.

“What do you mean?”

“The bamboo slips the Hidden Shadow Pavilion brought in earlier. Seventy-eight matters, to be exact. I’ve dealt with all of them.”

“…?”

All of them? In so little time?

Thousand-Faced Fox stared at the mountain of bamboo slips in the corner of the office. Then his eyes narrowed.

“Did you read the letter from Qinghai?”

“You mean the Kunlun Sect? Of course. It said they were pressed for time because they had to suppress bands of bandits and mounted bandits. It would be good if they arrived on time, but it should not matter much if they are a little late.”

“And the news from Sichuan?”

“Everyone is working together to speed the Tang Clan’s reconstruction. Ah, tell the Inner Hall to prepare an especially potent elixir. I heard the Family Head’s condition is poor. We should send substantial aid, but for now, we can at least do that much.”

“Then the letter from the Nanman Beast Palace…?”

“Was there one? I saw nothing about the Nanman Beast Palace among today’s matters.”

There was a simple reason for that. None of the matters submitted today had mentioned the Nanman Beast Palace.

Only then did a faint smile reach Thousand-Faced Fox's lips. Until now, he had only half believed Mae Jonghak.

"Hm? Why are you smiling?"

"It's nothing. I'm simply pleased to see you attending to your duties so—"

"Do not smile so slyly. Someone else might be horrified if they saw you."

"…"

"Anyway, the breeze is lovely. What a fine day."

Having spoiled Thousand-Faced Fox's mood, Mae Jonghak went back to gazing out the window. Then he spoke again.

"Would you like to take a walk outside with me? We may not have another day like this after today."

"I'd rather not."

Thousand-Faced Fox's answer was curt.

"I will send up another matter shortly, so do not do anything pointless, Alliance Leader. Get to work."

"An honored guest is arriving. The least I can do is go out and greet them."

"Greet them?"

Thousand-Faced Fox paused, then limped toward the window on his prosthetic leg.

"Look over there."

"…!"

Something was slowly approaching beyond the city wall.

It was still a considerable distance away and blurred by it, but once he focused his internal energy, he could easily make out a carriage.

What he could not explain was the familiar face on the driver's bench of that four-horse carriage.

Why is Shadow Killer there?

Shadow Killer was among the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's finest agents. At the Star-Array Grand Banquet, he had tracked Mae Jonghak while the Sword Saint was hiding his identity. During the Great Faction War, he had taken the heads of countless fiends.

"A familiar face, isn't it?" Mae Jonghak said.

"Yes. I sent Shadow Killer when I heard there was trouble on the main road, but…"

I sent him to capture them, and now he's escorting them here.

Thousand-Faced Fox swallowed the rest of his words as Mae Jonghak's voice reached his ears.

"An urgent report came while you were away," Mae Jonghak said.

"An urgent report?"

"Yes. Some welcome faces are on their way."

Mae Jonghak patted Thousand-Faced Fox's shoulder twice, then leaned out the window and muttered, "Come, let's go."

"Welcome."

The carriage entered the Murim Alliance's Inner City and came to a stop. The voice that greeted us as soon as we got down was fairly familiar.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

I'd once known him as Always-Victorious Sword Jongni Chu. He spotted me and gave a short laugh.

"How have you been, my friend?"

"…"

He's really sticking with that act.

I dipped my head in greeting. Mae Jonghak smacked his lips as if disappointed, then turned to Jeok Cheongang.

"I'm glad to see you looking well."

Jeok Cheongang, who had been yawning extravagantly while looking around, furrowed his brow.

"Were you speaking to this old man?"

"It has been a long time. I'm glad to see you again."

"You must have mistaken me for someone else. This old man has no particular connection to a brat whose blood hasn't even dried on his head…"

Jeok Cheongang trailed off. He looked Mae Jonghak up and down, and his eyes widened.

"Could it be you?"

"It is. It's me."

Mae Jonghak beamed.

"Since we've met again, would you consider becoming Alliance Leader?"

"…?"

"…?"

Is this the Murim version of picking a group-project captain?

Chapter 521

"Since it's good to see you again, let me ask you something. Would you consider becoming Alliance Leader?"

"…?"

"…?"

If the captain of a group project announced he was quitting, of course the other members would panic.

Mae Jonghak's question was so far beyond anything I'd expected that the Thunderbolt Saber King's mouth fell open. The Azure Sky Sword King and Unnamed stared at him in disbelief.

What does being glad to see him have to do with that…?

And this guy is the Alliance Leader?

They didn't say it aloud, but their faces did.

The last person there, Jeok Cheongang, looked astonishingly calm when he spoke.

"An ordinary person would be unable to continue speaking at a moment like this. But this old man is different. I have met an awful lot of crazy bastards lately."

The moment our eyes met, I turned around.

By an incredible coincidence, there was nobody behind me. Nobody except a sparrow pecking at something on the ground.

Oh, I see. That must be why he's looking this way.

"I didn't know you liked birds. Sparrows are cute, though."

"I'm looking at you."

"Me? Why me all of a sudden?"

"Do you really have to ask?"

"Usually people ask because they don't know. Why ask if they already do?"

"The way you're flapping that mouth makes me want to bury you."

That would be a problem.

I thought it over for a moment, then asked, not quite believing it myself, "This is just on the off chance—an extremely remote, one-in-a-million chance—but was I among the lunatics you mentioned?"

"Without question. Absolutely. Beyond the slightest doubt, your name is at the very top of the list."

"…"

I'd come dead last a few times in school, but this was my first time coming first.

I'm so glad I finally managed it—yeah, right. What the hell?

Jeok Cheongang, of all people, calling me a lunatic. And I ranked above Cheongpung.

The psychological damage made my vision swim. I stared at Jeok Cheongang and opened my mouth.

"There's this guy I know, Tess hyung.[2467] He once said, 'Know thyself.'"

"Was that directed at this old man?"

"Do you really have to ask?"

"You little son of a—"

His half-raised fist stopped. Sensing the stares gathering around us, Jeok Cheongang groaned and turned back to Mae Jonghak.

"In any case, I'll give you a straight answer. No."

"Ho. Why?"

"Too much trouble."

What an answer. You'd think he might at least be tempted, but he'd turned down the Alliance Leader's seat because he couldn't be bothered.

"Ah. Can't argue with that."

"…"

That was even better.

Please don't agree with him. Can't you see people slowly gathering around us?

We're screwed.

A dreadful thought crept up on me: if this conversation spread, the group project—the Murim Alliance—might fall apart.

Unfortunately, the two masterpieces facing each other were both shamelessly manly men who did not care about such things.

"A title like that doesn't suit me, and I don't like dealing with people."

"Ah. Neither do I."

"Then quit."

"I can't do that."

"Why?"

Mae Jonghak scratched his chin and tossed out a simple answer.

"Because someone has to do it."

"…!"

A man who had taken up a sword simply because he loved martial arts, then earned the name Sword Saint.

A true martial artist who, at the end of a brutal war, had turned his back on wealth and glory, chosen the life of a recluse, and returned to the mountains.

[2467] Tess hyung is a familiar Korean way of addressing Socrates, popularized by the song "Tess Hyung." *Hyung* is a man's familiar address for an older man.

But before he was a martial artist, Mae Jonghak was a Great Hero. He hadn't accepted the title of Alliance Leader out of some shallow desire for fame. He'd accepted it because he was both.

Someone has to do it.

The words were brief, but they carried weight. Jeok Cheongang gazed at Mae Jonghak, then let out a quiet laugh.

"Many years have passed, yet you haven't changed. It feels as though we met at Mount Jiuhua only yesterday."

Mae Jonghak's eyes widened.

"Yesterday? What are you talking about? That happened at least several decades ago."

"…"

"…"

Give me back my touching moment, you bastard.

I wasn't the only one who felt cheated. Under a shower of cold looks, Mae Jonghak tilted his head.

"Am I remembering it wrong?"

All trace of laughter vanished from Jeok Cheongang's face.

"…You really haven't changed. I can feel my insides rotting."

"Are you still unwell? I heard you had recovered fully from the poisoning."

"Shut that mouth of yours. If you keep talking, I don't know what this old man might do."

"Come to think of it, Great Hero Jeok, you were the first person ever to say that to me. This is why I like you."

"…Are you and that brat Cheongpung really just Master and Disciple? You're not related by blood?"

That question deserved a place among Murim's Seven Great Mysteries.

Everyone, myself included, was waiting for Mae Jonghak's answer with pounding hearts when an elderly voice sounded behind us.

"As far as I know, the Alliance Leader and the Huashan Divine Dragon are not related by blood."

I recognized the old man limping toward us on a prosthetic leg.

Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho.

The former Chief of the Murim Alliance's Hidden Shadow Pavilion, now restored to the same post in the New Murim Alliance, bowed slightly.

"Please come upstairs. Refreshments are ready."

The Murim Alliance was crowded.

People with the character *Alliance* embroidered in silver thread on their chests moved about everywhere. They weren't all armed martial artists, either. Quite a few wore neat scholars' robes.

Those people…

Song Ho hadn't won his post as Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion in a game of Go-Stop.[2468] Walking beside me, he seemed to read the question in my glance at once.

"They serve directly under the Alliance Leader's Office."

"They don't look like they're from the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families."

"Good eye. Because they serve directly under the Alliance Leader's Office, we didn't select anyone who belongs to another sect or whose identity hasn't been thoroughly verified. We have to protect confidential information. This way."

The Murim Alliance grounds were as vast as a plain and as complicated as a maze. Pavilions and other buildings stood packed together wherever I looked, and shouts rang out from a distant training ground.

When I first got off the carriage, I'd thought we were already in the Inner City. But the farther we went, the tighter security became and the fewer people I saw.

No. It'd be more accurate to say I couldn't see them.

They could hold their breath and use the most advanced concealment techniques they liked. I could still sense them—on the walls, above the ceiling, hidden in the dark. I felt their gazes and their qi as they watched this place.

"I've been wondering for a while. Are those people from the Hidden Shadow Pavilion?"

Song Ho's eyes widened slightly at the sudden question.

"When did you notice them?"

"When we passed the fifth door."

"Can you still sense them?"

"Yes."

"Remarkable. Truly remarkable. Those four were trained as assassins even within the Hidden Shadow Pavilion. To detect every one of them…"

I scratched my chin as he marveled.

"Do you really not know, or are you testing me?"

"Hm? What do you mean?"

"If it's a test, it's not much fun. There are five, not four."

Ssss.

[2468] Go-Stop is a Korean card game played with *hwatu*, or flower cards.

A torch hanging on the wall stirred, then went still. It was the only sign that the Hidden Shadow Pavilion agents concealed nearby had been shaken. Their leader's gaze grew intent.

"I suspected as much. So it wasn't a coincidence."

"Actually, I guessed."

"…"

"Kidding. Your people are all skilled. I nearly walked right past without noticing them."

Something flashed in Song Ho's eyes. Unlike when he'd been testing me, his admiration and curiosity now seemed genuine.

"Extraordinary. From the information I'd gathered, I thought I had a fairly accurate idea of your martial ability… Have you gained some new insight lately?"

Insight.

I thought of my ten days of training while drifting down the Yangtze and nodded.

The greatest thing I'd gained from the training Mungyeong prescribed was finer control over qi itself, the source of martial arts. Before, it had been like handling a thick rope. Now it was more like handling a spool of thread.

That had improved my understanding of how to use my internal energy, and my Qi Sense had sharpened along with it.

"Maybe a little."

"Your rate of growth is frightening. Almost unbelievable."

The Thunderbolt Saber King, who'd been glancing at me for some time, muttered, "It is… In all my years, I've never seen a monster like you. You'll make a fine rival for my eldest grandson."

"And your eldest grandson's name is…?"

"Peng Dojin."

"Pengdori?[2469] Sure, he's a good starter Pokémon. Cute, too."

"What the hell are you talking about? Peng Dojin! Peng Dojin! The one who gave you a close fight at the Star-Array Grand Banquet!"

Jeok Cheongang, who'd been swaggering along like a back-alley thug, kindly supplied the details.

"The one you beat like a dog for fifteen minutes until he surrendered. Was he thirty?"

"Oh, right. I remember now. By the end, he was using his saber as a cane."

"Y-you…!"

"It's all right. When you're young, you get beaten here and there. You lose sometimes."

Jeok Cheongang lit up like a child who'd received a Christmas present.

[2469] Pengdori is the Korean name for Piplup, a penguin Pokémon that players can choose as a starter.

“Peng, it’ll be the same when he’s older, so don’t get your hopes up. Try as he might, he’ll only end up like his grandfather—unable to Return to Youth, growing old and dying.”

“You son of a—!”

“Ahem.”

No matter how I looked at it, the Azure Sky Sword King was the greatest victim here. He hadn’t said a word, yet the blows kept landing on him too. The skin beneath the old swordsman’s eyes twitched.

Mae Jonghak’s next remark finished him off.

“Don’t be so impatient, everyone. Keep at it and it’ll happen naturally.”

“…!”

“…!”

Was that supposed to be words or a fart?

If Returning to Youth happened naturally, half the martial artists in the world would’ve done it already.

The Thunderbolt Saber King and the Azure Sky Sword King fell silent, unable even to get angry at a remark Mae Jonghak had made without a trace of malice. Just then, the largest, tallest pavilion I’d seen in the Murim Alliance came into view.

“Please come inside.”

At first, I thought it must be where the Alliance Leader lived. I knew I was wrong before we even opened the door.

Tadadadak!

“A letter from Jiangsu!”

“What’s the Grade?”

“Earth Grade.”

“Organize the related matters and relay them. Have So Pyeong, Hwangso, and Jang Il-pal submit their reports within half an hour.”

Shff, shff, shff!

People hurried around the pavilion. Bamboo slips and documents traveled through a bewildering network of cylinders running throughout the building.

Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho watched the entire chaotic scene carefully before opening his mouth.

“Hubei. Wudang. Heaven Grade.”

Someone in scholars’ robes heard the three brief words and pulled a ring.

A moment later—

Whoosh! Thunk!

A bamboo slip dropped through the cylinder beside us and unfurled.

“This is why we summoned you here. It is an urgent report that arrived from the Wudang Sect of Hubei five days ago.”

I didn’t hear a word he said.
I was staring at what was on the bamboo slip—not the writing, but the drawing.
The Water God Dragon… wasn’t the whole story.
Something unidentifiable had been drawn in black ink.
It was a monster unfamiliar to some, yet strangely familiar to others.

Chapter 522

Fuck. One problem after another.

I felt like I'd been walloped in the back of the head.

Nothing in this world was absolute, but I had still thought the events in Hubei had been wrapped up properly…

The Water God Dragon wasn't the only thing affected by magical power.

Had another Gate opened somewhere? Or had magical power the Water God Dragon failed to absorb leaked out and affected something else?

Looking at the drawing left my mouth feeling gritty, as if I'd been chewing sand.

I wasn't the only one who understood how serious this was.

"What in the world is that?"

"One thing seems certain. Whatever it is, it cannot be called human."

The Thunderbolt Saber King and the Azure Sky Sword King muttered to themselves. Mae Jonghak spoke up.

"According to Wudang, that bizarre creature is the Killing Ghost that has been terrorizing Hubei of late."

"The Killing Ghost?"

Jeok Cheongang frowned and looked at me. I understood the question in his eyes and nodded.

"It's probably the one you're thinking of."

"Damn it. Darkest beneath the lamp, indeed."

He was right. This was exactly what that saying meant.

But in this case, we couldn't have noticed. The lamp had been so bright we could barely open our eyes.

With hundreds of people dying across Hubei Province, it would have been strange to pay much attention to a Killing Ghost Wudang was already pursuing. Especially when the culprit we'd finally uncovered was an imugi[2470] driven mad by magical power.

We didn't have time to worry about anything else.

It hadn't occurred to me that another monster might appear. I'd assumed the Killing Ghost was just another lunatic of the kind you found all over Murim.

But what kind of monster is this bastard?

Drawings from this era looked about like the ones in history textbooks. The drawing on the bamboo slip was no different.

Whoever had made it had clearly tried to be accurate, but it fell short in all sorts of ways, including any sense of depth.

[2470] An imugi is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.

There was only one thing I could tell from it: as the Azure Sky Sword King had said, this thing wasn't human.

A horn jutted from the middle of its forehead. Its arms and legs were absurdly long and thick. Its eyes, the only part drawn in color, were red. This was beyond anything you could explain with the words *demonic, heterodox arts*.

Definitely a monster. But had magical power mutated it, like the Water God Dragon?

Tap. Tap.

I drummed my fingers anxiously against the wall.

"Are there any other drawings?"

Thousand-Faced Fox, who'd been watching me closely, nodded.

"Unfortunately, no. That was the best Wudang could do."

"That's a shame. But I doubt this is all you have."

"You're quick. A second letter arrived from Wudang two days ago."

At a glance from Thousand-Faced Fox, the middle-aged scholar pulled the ring again.

Whoosh! Thunk!

An oval wooden case slid down the round tube. Inside was a letter densely covered in writing.

"Read it yourself. You were at the center of what happened in Hubei. You may spot something the Hidden Shadow Pavilion and I missed."

"I was planning to do that anyway."

"This old man will read it too," Jeok Cheongang said.

We put our heads together and read the letter. Once didn't seem enough, so we read it a second time, then a third. Only after fifteen minutes did we look up.

"What do you think?" Thousand-Faced Fox asked.

Jeok Cheongang frowned. "Hard to say."

"I see."

"…Why aren't you asking me anything else?"

Because I wasn't expecting much from you in the first place.

Not that I had much to add myself. From what the letter said, Thousand-Faced Fox and the Hidden Shadow Pavilion had already pieced together some of the circumstances behind the monster's appearance.

"As you've read, this monster was once a fisherman who lived at the mouth of the Yangtze," Thousand-Faced Fox said.

I pointed to the first line of the letter. "Jang Sam. In his fifties, with a family."

Wudang hadn't assumed a monster like this had simply dropped out of the sky. They'd examined its corpse closely, found several distinguishing features, and investigated. That had led them to a fisherman from a village less than a hundred

li[2471] from Mount Wudang.

“They say he went out alone to fish more than a month ago and vanished without a trace. When he failed to return after several days, his children petitioned the local authorities.”

The authorities probably couldn’t have found him. Fishermen did die now and then, and Hubei Province had been gripped by fear and chaos after one disaster after another.

When even high-ranking people were dropping dead here and there like minions in some canyon, who was going to worry about one fisherman?

Even if they had actively searched for him, they probably couldn’t have found him.

Even Wudang’s masters had taken quite some time to catch Jang Sam. The local authorities would have had no better luck.

How had an aging fisherman, once as ordinary as they came, become a hideous monster known as the Killing Ghost?

“Any idea what caused it?” Thousand-Faced Fox asked.

“The Blood Fish seem the likeliest cause.”

“I’ve already received the report on them. I sent several Hidden Shadow Pavilion agents to Hubei with orders to capture a live one.”

“Good call. Jang Sam, who became a mon—who became a monster, was originally a fisherman, and Dongting Lake is connected to the tributaries of the Yangtze…”

Mae Jonghak, who’d been listening quietly, murmured, “He might have eaten a Blood Fish that came down one of those tributaries.”

“Or been eaten by one.”

“…!”

“…!”

“Either way, that seems likeliest for now. It would explain his appearance and how he grew strong enough to evade Wudang for days.”

Thousand-Faced Fox’s expression hardened. “What about the possibility that the same thing happened somewhere else, as it did with the imugi[2472] you defeated? What you call a ‘rift.‘”

“…”

“Tell me. I wanted to hear it from you.”

They called it a rift here. I called it a Gate.

Of course I’d considered the possibility. I just didn’t want to think about it, let alone say it aloud.

I wasn’t superstitious, but there was that saying about speaking things into existence. Honestly, I wanted to rule out even the slightest chance.

[2471] This uses the Chinese li, about 500 m (0.311 mi). A hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi).

[2472] An imugi is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.

Still, I could not avoid answering. I opened my mouth with an uncomfortable expression.

"I can't be certain, but I think it's unlikely."

"Why?"

"If the same thing had happened, it wouldn't have ended with just this."

No second Gate had opened. That was my conclusion.

We should have been relieved. Yet the few of us who knew what a Gate meant—including me—looked grim. They'd understood what I was really saying.

Put simply:

It hasn't happened yet. But if another Gate blows, we're truly fucked.

"A powder keg," Thousand-Faced Fox murmured. "A powder keg, indeed."

A powder keg was safe as long as no fire touched it. But that also meant it became more dangerous than anything else the moment someone set it alight.

You'd wonder what kind of lunatic would do that, except the lunatics of Dark Heaven had already set Hubei Province's powder keg alight once.

Murim as it stood was like a vast powder keg on the verge of exploding.

And the second and third Gates would be the enormous sparks that set it off.

There is one small mercy.

I didn't know who the bastard called the Lord of Heaven really was, or how the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had opened a Gate. But I could make one guess.

Opening a Gate isn't easy for them either.

A Gate wasn't an inn door. If Dark Heaven could fling them open whenever they pleased, Murim would already be a complete disaster.

Orcs would have founded sects, while Lycanthropes and ogres would be walking arm in arm down the main roads of Henan.

Before the Murim Alliance could even be formed, everyone would be shouting, *Uh, fuck, what are those things?* Then we would have fallen apart completely.

But Dark Heaven hadn't done that.

Why? Because it was hard.

Which meant we had to hurry. We had to stop them before another powder keg blew.

And there was a second mercy: this vast group, united under the Murim Alliance's banner, had the strength to do it.

"…Calamity has come to Murim," Mae Jonghak murmured with a sigh. "On a far greater scale than I imagined."

Thousand-Faced Fox turned to him, his face set. "There's something I must look into at once. Alliance Leader, forgive me, but would you and the others move elsewhere?"

"Of course."

"Understood. I'll report to you later. Until next time, everyone."

That was the last he said to us.

Before we had even left the pavilion, urgent shouts rang out from every direction. The people who had been worn down by exhaustion opened their eyes wide as though they had never been tired and began moving according to their orders.

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion, which had kept itself alive even after the Murim Alliance's dissolution, was moving again.

They weren't the only ones about to get busy.

"I should go as well," Mae Jonghak said. "There will soon be a mountain of work waiting for me."

The Azure Sky Sword King nodded. "The same goes for me. May I tell my good-for-nothing son what I heard here today?"

"You seem to have forgotten who brought you here."

If the information were too secret to share with anyone, the Alliance Leader and the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion wouldn't have brought us all here themselves.

The Azure Sky Sword King understood and clasped his hands in salute.

"Thank you."

"Everyone will know in a few days. Until then, take care that nothing gets out."

"Of course. I'll keep that in mind."

The Thunderbolt Saber King seemed to grasp the gravity of the situation too. His face was stiff as he spoke.

"Hey, Sword Saint. I have something to ask as well."

"The Hebei Peng Family may be told too. There's no reason—"

"No, not that. What in the world were you all talking about in there?"

"…"

"…"

Is the Hebei Peng Family's Grand Family Head really this low on Intelligence? My pecs are swelling with pride…

Everyone, including me, gave him a cold stare. The Thunderbolt Saber King mumbled a defense.

"You could at least talk about something a man can understand. I know a great pleasure has come to Murim, but…"

"Peng."

"Yeah?"

"Then shut your mouth for a while. This old man thinks that would help."

"What did you say?!"

Jeok Cheongang heaved a sigh at the Thunderbolt Saber King, then looked at Mae Jonghak.

“I’ll handle this stupid old man. Go on. You must be busy.”
“Thank you. By the way, Great Hero Jeok.”
“Speak.”
Mae Jonghak took Jeok Cheongang’s hand and held it tight.
“Are you *sure* you won’t be Alliance Leader?”
“…”
“…”
Be honest. You and Cheongpung are blood relatives, aren’t you?

Chapter 523

Ssssss.

Hot. Scorching Yang Qi surged from my dantian, spreading through my limbs and bones and racing along my acupoints. Everything felt still and vividly clear.

I circulated my internal energy through the Eight Extraordinary Meridians.

Once, twice, three times…

Circulating qi was like rolling a snowball down a high hill. With every pass, the snowball grew. But it could also pick up dirt, stones, and twigs along the way.

Those impurities were turbid qi. They muddied the purity of my internal energy, and each pass burned away more of them, refining it.

More. More. More.

I kept circulating my energy, repeating the words to myself as if entranced.

Three jiazi[2473] of internal energy took the shape of a fire dragon and swam unhindered through my body. In the image I held in my mind, the dragon grew larger, its heat burning hotter.

Then I knew.

Now.

Fwoosh.

At my command, Scorching Yang Qi surged in every direction. The heat was overwhelming, as though a small sun had burst inside me.

My closed eyes grew hot. Flames seemed to pour from my nose instead of breath.

No—it wasn't just a feeling. That had to be what was happening.

Water overflowed when there was too much of it. Now the internal energy filling my body was flowing out.

Heat poured from my eyes, nose, mouth, and the other openings known as the seven apertures, scorching the air around me. The same thing was happening through the countless pores all over my body.

Ssssss.

I could feel an immense flow of qi gathering above my crown. At the same time, I began to draw on the blank canvas of my mind.

I was my own master. Every acupoint in my body was mine, as was every strand of qi that had flowed out of it. None could defy my will.

I couldn't see the Scorching Yang Qi above my head, but I could feel it taking the shape I wanted.

One, two, three.

Three petals, red as though they were burning.

[2473] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi amount to 180 years.

Three Flowers Gather at the Crown.

This was what enlightenment had brought to my Supreme Peak realm.

It was a realm any martial artist in the world would dream of reaching. For me, though, it was only the first hill.

Hoo.

The short breath I let out carried the last traces of turbid qi I'd filtered away. Once I had expelled even that final handful, leaving my internal energy and mind clear, I stepped toward the next hill.

Five Qi Returning to Origin.

I'd attempted it several times since opening my Middle Dantian, but I'd never succeeded. Another wall stood in my way.

I'll get past it. Right now.

A sharp tingle ran through my chest as I made up my mind.

I couldn't lose this edge of tension. Punching blindly at a wall would only hurt my fist. If I wanted to put even a hairline crack in it, I had to stay alert and read the flow precisely.

Let my guard down for even a moment, and my internal energy could reverse its flow.

Following a road someone else had laid was easy. I was carving out a new one of my own. I had to move boulders, cut through undergrowth—and I could always slip while climbing a cliff.

A reversal would cause an Internal Injury. If I kept forcing my way forward while injured, I'd be asking for qi deviation.

According to Jeok Cheongang, plenty of martial artists had died or been left half-crippled that way. I had no intention of ending up in a wheelchair while Dark Heaven was taking a gigantic dump all over Murim.

Slowly. Carefully.

Fortunately, training with Mungyeong had helped a great deal.

The Scorching Yang Qi I'd built through the Fire Gate Divine Technique—the cultivation technique at the heart of the Fire Gate Clan—had power and explosiveness to rival the techniques of other prestigious sects. Its movements, however, were correspondingly rough.

This training had helped me make up for some of that weakness.

I can do this. As long as I keep my head clear, I can do it.

It was warm. The Three Flowers Gather at the Crown trembled above my head.

Don't worry. Internal energy is faster than hands.

First ring.

I had just begun to move my internal energy with care when someone spoke.

"Rein it in. Trying now is a waste of effort anyway."

"…!"

Crack!

The sudden voice shattered my concentration. The internal energy taking shape as Five Qi Returning to Origin scattered.

At the same time, my internal energy reversed its flow. Gastric juices surged up from deep inside my body, and I vomited.

"Ooooooogh!"

Splash.

Vomit flecked with blood spilled across the floor.

Fuck. So this is where the Niagara Falls I saw in pictures were hiding.

I poured out what had come up and stood panting. Then I saw the side dishes I'd eaten that morning waving at me from the floor.

"Uweeegh! Bleeegh!"

Ah. Couldn't hold that back.

Only after emptying my stomach several more times did my mind finally clear. I glared at the owner of the leather shoes who had already moved a considerable distance away.

"What are you doing?"

Mungyeong inspected the shoes on his feet before answering.

"I only bought these three days ago. I'd rather they didn't get dirty."

"Not that. Why did you talk to me while I was circulating my qi?"

"I didn't even shake you, so what's the problem? You've reached that realm, yet your composure is shattered by a few words. That is your deficiency."

"You startled me!"

"You startled me too. What the hell have you been eating yesterday and today to produce so much…?"

Mungyeong frowned at the vomit spread across the floor.

"The longer I look, the filthier it gets. Though from the shape, it does bear a passing resemblance to Five Qi Returning to Origin."

"Hey, Mr. Mun!"

"Mr. *what?*"

I held Mungyeong's cold stare.

One second. Two seconds. Three.

Hmm. That should do it.

"Slip of the tongue. I must have suffered a serious Internal Injury."

"Looking at you makes my qi-sea acupoint throb."

I avoided his flat stare and hurriedly changed the subject.

"What brings you here all of a sudden? No, wait. How did you get in?"

“What do you think the door is for?”

“But Mujin’s guarding the door…”

My voice trailed off.

Slide. Thump!

A figure collapsed with a faint flop through the half-open doorway.

The back of the head was so familiar that my eyes widened before I could stop them.

“Mujin! Hyuk Mujin!”

“Leave him,” Mungyeong said in a grim voice. “He won’t wake up even if you shake him.”

He wouldn’t wake up even if I shook him?

That blood-crazed Killing Ghost had finally done it.

I roared furiously.

“You cold-blooded murderer! You’re just like that bastard the Slaughter Saint!”

“He was asleep blocking the door. I tried to wake him, but he wouldn’t budge… What did you just say?”

“Huh?”

“I asked what you said.”

“What?”

What the fuck?

Right on cue, Hyuk Mujin’s corpse—no, his body—stirred. A vigorous snore followed.

Grrrrrr.

“…”

“…”

Our gazes met in silence. I gave Mungyeong a charming smile.

“There seems to have been a very slight, insignificant misunderstanding.”

“It didn’t sound like a misunderstanding. Or an insignificant one.”

“Can’t we just agree that good is good?”

“Dead is dead?”

“Oh… How did you get *that* from what I said?”

“Why couldn’t I? Do you have a problem with it?”

I did have a problem with it, and his cochlea also seemed to have a serious problem, but I lacked the courage to point that out.

“I was wrong.”

“And an apology settles everything?”

“I believe a sincere conversation can untangle any knot.”

"Good. Go have one with Dark Heaven's Lord of Heaven, then. Now wipe that irritating smile off your face before I tear your mouth apart."

"Our ancestors said you can't spit in a smiling face."

"Ptui."

Splat.

Hmm. Our ancestors were wrong.

At times like this, I had to regain my composure. I calmly wiped the spit from my cheek.

"That came out incredibly fast. I thought it was a hidden weapon."

"If I put internal energy behind it, I can burst someone's eyeballs."

"Impressive. Are you Zerg,[2474] by any chance?"

"I'm the Grim Reaper."

"…Once again, I'm very sorry."

Mungyeong looked at me as if calculating how many pieces he'd have to cut me into for people to say he'd killed me properly. Then he clicked his tongue.

"Enough. Every time I talk to you, it drains me."

"…"

He's one to talk. I'm losing life force by the second.

I'd bet Hyuk Mujin's left atrium that conversation had shaved at least three days off my life.

I told that bastard Hyuk Mujin to stand guard. He couldn't even resist falling asleep again.

Mungyeong was something else, but Hyuk Mujin was no less impressive.

"So what brings you here…?"

"That sounded like 'What shitty thing have you come here to do this time?'"

"Oh."

"Oh?"

"Oh… no. I was just curious."

"Your pronunciation seems to have grown rather strange since I last saw you. Must be my imagination."

"Of course. Just your imagination."

Mungyeong sighed quietly and tossed me the bundle in his hand.

Thump.

I caught it reflexively and stared at it with wide eyes.

"What's this?"

"A pill."

"A pill?"

[2474] The Zerg are an insect-like alien species in the *StarCraft* games.

Is it Santa Claus in spring? What's with the sudden present?

I opened the bundle, still unsure what to make of it, and found a small, sturdy-looking wooden case inside. A strange fragrance reached deep into my nose.

This is…

They said you could tell how potent some elixirs were before you even saw them. Now I understood what they meant. I knew the pill inside was powerful before I opened the case.

Click.

When I opened the case, a reddish pill came into view. Even at first glance, it was clearly no ordinary pill.

I stared at it for a moment, then looked up at Mungyeong.

"What are you looking at?"

"Why are you giving me something like this all of a sudden?"

"It holds a considerable amount of fire qi. It'll help you."

"What?"

"Is there a hidden weapon stuck in your ear? Don't make me say it twice."

"No, I wasn't asking what it does…"

Mungyeong's face crumpled. For someone who spent most of his time looking bleak, it was a remarkable display of emotion.

"I found it on the way here."

"…?"

"Let me correct that. I saw it while passing by and bought it. Satisfied?"

What do you mean, satisfied, old man?

I touched the red pill in its case.

Item check.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Mungyeong's Specially Crafted Pill for Jin Taekyung
Would you like to view more detailed information?
Y / N

Yeah. No. That's enough.

I closed the small System window and gave Mungyeong a lukewarm look.

"'Saw it while passing by and bought it.' Right."

"…What's that look for?"

"Nothing. Thank you. I'll take it."

What I felt toward Mungyeong was half gratitude, half fear.

I appreciate the good pill, but what the hell is the next training session going to be…?

Being treated this well all of a sudden felt like being fed a good meal before an execution.

As if he understood what my trembling gaze meant, Mungyeong opened his mouth.

Chapter 524

Hyuk Mujin woke up fifteen minutes after Mungyeong left.

He poked his head through the gap in the open door. The moment our eyes met, he spoke with a solemn expression.

“Your qi circulation is complete.”

“Yeah. Your life is about to be over, too.”

“Hyuk Mujin, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan. As the Captain ordered, I was guarding the door so that not even a single ant could get inside.”

“…Are you seriously insane?”

Look at this bastard, acting proud after letting in everything *but* the ants.

It was ridiculous, but I decided to give him high marks for the sheer nerve it took to lie so brazenly after snoring his head off.

“Close the door and get lost.”

“Yes, sir.”

Perhaps he felt guilty, because he didn’t offer even a word of protest before scampering away.

Just as he was about to shut the door, something occurred to me.

“Wait. What about the others?”

“Who do you mean by ‘the others’…?”

“All of them.”

Hyuk Mujin thought for a moment.

“First, the Lesser Family Head is meeting with the Sect Leaders and Family Heads of the other factions.”

“The Sect Leaders and Family Heads?”

“Yes. It seems he’s been meeting with them more often for the past two days.”

Two days ago. That was when a few of us, including Jeok Cheongang and me, had gone to the Murim Alliance.

It was about time the subject came up.

At the very least, the heads of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families should have received some warning.

With all sorts of information and problems related to Dark Heaven coming to light, it was only natural for them to put their heads together and devise a countermeasure.

“Oh, and we handed the Three Fiend over to the Murim Alliance. I heard they were going to bring in some master to interrogate him…”

“Really?”

The third of the Qilian Three Fiends, who had stained Sichuan with blood under the Western Heaven Demon Lord's command, was remarkably hard to kill.

Plenty had happened while he was bound and brought all the way to Henan, yet unlike his two brothers, his head was still attached to his neck. That alone proved how lucky the bastard was.

It was just a different part that had fallen off instead.

If he kept saying he didn't know anything even while they were cutting off his balls, I doubt an interrogation will get much more out of him.

Even for a Supreme Peak master—hell, for anyone—one's balls were precious.

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin had once held a hundred-minute debate over which mattered most: a man's life, his dantian, or his balls.

Anyway, I handed the Three Fiend over as ordered. The Murim Alliance can handle the rest.

Well, what happened after that was none of my concern. I could only hope the Murim Alliance managed to obtain more information about Dark Heaven through further interrogation.

"Forget my eldest brother. What about the others? I haven't seen them anywhere."

"Gung Gibang moved to a different lodging."

"He moved? When?"

"About one or two shichen[2475] ago. You were busy circulating your qi, so I took the message for you."

"…You weren't asleep then?"

"What are you talking about? I told you I stood guard like an iron wall."

"Ugh. Every time this bastard opens his mouth—"

I raised my fist, and Hyuk Mujin hurried on.

"The Beggars' Sect! He said he would be staying at the Henan branch of the Beggars' Sect, so we should come find him anytime something happens."

I stopped just short of hitting him.

"The Beggars' Sect? Why would he go there?"

"What?"

Hyuk Mujin looked at me as though I'd said something absurd.

"May I ask which faction you belong to, Captain?"

"What kind of stupid question is that? The Jin Family of Taiyuan or the Fire Gate Clan, obviously."

"And Gung Gibang?"

"…Oh, shit. Right. He's the Beggars' Sect's Successor Beggar."

[2475] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; one or two shichen is about two to four hours.

I had forgotten because he clung to me like a burr. Come to think of it, he had a master and a sect of his own. It would be unreasonable for him to stay with us even in Henan.

“Wait. Did Cheongpung leave too?”

“Of course.”

“…Really?”

It’ll be quiet for a while, then.

And yet I felt both relieved and disappointed. I’d keep seeing them both, of course, but without those two making a racket all the time, I could already feel the empty space they’d left behind.

“They could’ve at least said goodbye before leaving.”

At my mutter, Hyuk Mujin looked me up and down as though I were some strange creature.

“Why would they say goodbye?”

“Why are you so heartless? We’ve spent all this time together, and they just leave without saying goodbye?”

“Do they need to say goodbye when they’re only going out for a bit?”

“…?”

“They went to the marketplace to buy sweetmeats and dumplings.”

“…!”

Shit. Give me back my sentimentality.

I was momentarily speechless. Hyuk Mujin cast me a meaningful look.

“Captain.”

“Shut up.”

“I haven’t said anything yet.”

“That’s why I’m telling you to shut up.”

“I’ll stay by your side no matter what happens, Captain.”

“…Please get away from me.”

“Come on. You like it, so why are you acting like this?”

I was annoyed, but worse than that, I was embarrassed as hell.

I sighed. Hyuk Mujin, still needling me, suddenly seemed to remember something.

“By the way, you haven’t asked about Mungyeong.”

“I already saw him.”

“You did? He’s seemed pretty busy lately, too. He’s been gathering strange medicinal ingredients, boiling them, pounding them… He looked completely swamped. When did you see him?”

“While you were asleep, you bastard!”

Wham! Wham! Wham!

"Urgh! Oof! Gah!"

"Go! Get out right now!"

After taking a thorough beating, Hyuk Mujin looked at me with tears welling in his eyes.

"Do you hate me that much?"

I immediately shook my head.

"No. I want to kill you."

"That's too harsh. Really."

"I told you to stand guard for a moment, and you went to sleep! You slept long enough to dream the entire *Dream of the Nine Clouds*.[2476] You bastard."

"Why do you only hate me, Captain?! I hate you too!"

"…"

Tap-tap-tap. Slam!

I was speechless as Hyuk Mujin ran off, scattering tears behind him.

What the hell.

The guy was well past his mid-twenties, and that was what he came out with? My fists were growing grander by the second.

I was letting out a heartfelt sigh when the door opened again and Hyuk Mujin poked his head through the gap.

"Um…"

"Welcome back. Our Mujin has come to pick out his burial plot."

"No. That's not it. I came because I was worried you might misunderstand."

"What?"

"I didn't shut the door that hard on purpose. The wind was strong."

"…"

"Well, I'll be going now. Good work, sir. Loyalty."[2477]

Should I really kill him?

He was acting exactly like an elementary school kid who'd just been scolded by his mother. I glared at the door as it closed again, this time as gently as a door could close, then shook my head.

I turned back to the empty space I'd been looking at before Hyuk Mujin woke up.

Item Window

[2476] *The Dream of the Nine Clouds* is a classic Korean novel in which a man experiences an entire lifetime within a dream.

[2477] "Loyalty" translates *chungseong*, a word used as a military salute in Korea.

SYSTEM

Mungyeong's Specially Crafted Custom Pill for Jin Taekyung
Type: Elixir
Grade: Peak
Restriction: None (effect increases if taken by **Jin Taekyung**)
Description: A pill focused on stability and recovery rather than increasing internal energy. If taken when internal energy is unstable, it steadies the user's qi and greatly increases their recovery.
Special Note: Made with **Jin Taekyung** in mind. He will receive an even greater effect if he takes it.

"…Hmm."

I stroked the reddish pill—otherwise known as the *Mungyeong Special Jin Custom Pill*—then put it back in its wooden case.

Inventory open. Store.

A System notification appeared, telling me the item had been stored.

But my mind was already on the conversation I'd had with Mungyeong before he left.

"Training ends here."

"Pardon?"

"Why? Are you disappointed?"

A lot of emotions seemed to pass through me in that moment. After hesitating, I answered,

"…To be honest, I can't say I'm glad to hear it."

"Why?"

"I want to get stronger. Much stronger than I am now."

"Greedy bastard. Aren't you strong enough already?"

"Isn't that how people are? No matter how much we have, we always want more."

Mungyeong stared at me for a long time after I questioned him in return, then let out a quiet laugh.

It was the first time I'd seen him smile since we met.

"You're finally starting to sound like a Murim practitioner."

"I am a Murim practitioner."

"Then let me ask you again. Do you want to become an assassin, or a Murim practitioner?"

"I want to be strong. So strong no one would dare touch me. Strong enough that everyone around me would be safe just because I'm there."

"The Invincible… That's an ambitious dream."

The Invincible. The word sounded distant and grandiose.

Even the Martial God had enemies. The Heavenly Demon, master of the Demonic Cult, and the hundred thousand soldiers of the Demonic Path under his command had been the Martial God's adversaries.

"You really do dream big."

"Even if reality is a cesspit, your dreams should be big and lofty."

"Funny. That's obviously ridiculous bluster, but coming from you, it sounds almost plausible."

"Pardon?"

"Nothing. And if that's your reason, then you must not learn my martial arts."

"Why?"

"Too much of anything becomes poison. You don't need two wells right now."

"…I should dig only one well?"

"Did you just speak informally to me?"

"No, that's not what I meant."

"I made this decision after a great deal of thought. Keep that in mind."

"Is it because I lack talent?"

I'd asked as Mungyeong was about to leave.

His answer was short.

"The opposite."

"Pardon?"

"If you were weak and untalented, I'd have taught you more. You'd need to learn whatever you could to survive."

Those words suddenly brought back my days as an F-rank Hunter.

No matter how carefully you chose your position and approached a fight, danger could be lurking anywhere.

Without a tank's protection or cover from a mage or archer, you were ultimately on your own.

If I dropped my spear by mistake, I cut a goblin's throat with the dagger I carried. If the dagger broke, I picked up a rock and smashed in its head.

I did whatever it took to survive.

I hadn't picked a spear because I had any special talent for it. I'd figured that keeping some distance between myself and the monsters might improve my chances of staying alive.

"Judging by your expression, something's occurred to you."

"…I think I understand some of what you mean."

"The martial arts I learned are different in nature from the Fire Gate Clan's. I was raised as an assassin from the start, and I spent more than half my life as one. We

began in different places. Even if I taught you my martial arts, you'd likely be unable to make them your own simply by following the formulas."

"Is that why you're ending my training? I thought we'd barely started."

"Started? You already know everything."

"Pardon?"

"What matters isn't martial arts. It's martial principles. Those principles are everything I have. They're the foundation on which the name Slaughter Saint was built."

I could still remember the look in his eyes. I couldn't begin to tell what lay behind it.

And I could still remember his voice.

"There were three hundred of us at first. We all learned the same martial arts and underwent the same training. Ten years later, only twenty of those three hundred raised as assassins remained. Ten years after that, only one remained."

I didn't need to ask who the last person was.

Mungyeong looked back into the distant past with that inscrutable gaze, then turned away. He left me with one final instruction.

"I taught you the martial principles you needed most. Combining martial arts of different kinds is nearly impossible, but principles have no such divide. Work those principles into the martial arts you've learned. That's your final task."

Thump. Thump.

I came out of my thoughts. A familiar presence outside was knocking on the door.

"Hyuk Mujin?"

"Captain. It's time. You should come out."

It's time?

The question vanished almost as soon as it arose.

I suddenly realized what day it was.

The Murim Alliance.

Today, all of Murim would stand beneath a single banner.

Chapter 525

The Alliance Leader's Hall was silent. Only one person remained where countless people had come and gone just one shichen—approximately two hours—earlier.

"How quickly the years pass."

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak murmured the words under his breath. His youthful face was turned toward empty space, but his gaze was searching a distant past. Few people alive still shared those old memories.

They're all gone now.

Of those who shared Mae Jonghak's memories, very few had lived out their natural spans. Most had fallen in nameless wastelands and fields, never to rise again.

The monster known as the Great Faction War had claimed countless lives and turned the survivors into heroes.

But in the end… here we are again.

Enough time had passed for the mountains and rivers to change four times over.

Peace had come to the world. The pain and sorrow of war had faded, and orthodox Murim had sung of the glory of victory.

Then a dark cloud called Dark Heaven appeared in a sky that had seemed destined to remain blue forever.

Peace is over.

The runny-nosed child who had not understood the horrors of war had become middle-aged, while the young man who had drawn his weapon and burned with righteous indignation had grown old.

Those who had not even been born back then had come to Henan seeking glory rather than justice.

Their lives, personalities, and goals were all different.

And Sword Saint Mae Jonghak knew it well. He—and no one else—would have to lead them all into battle once again. He would have to defeat Dark Heaven, which sought to plunge the world into misery.

That was when a low voice slipped between Mae Jonghak's firmly closed lips.

"Every now and then, I wonder whether I can truly do it."

He was not talking to himself. Mae Jonghak knew it, and so did the person who had been quietly standing guard by the door.

Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho, a sturdy old man, stepped forward as he answered.

"You can."

Clack.

The tip of his prosthetic leg struck the floor, the sound echoing unusually loudly. Beneath his hanging white hair, his shrewd eyes shone with force.

“No—you must.”

“I know.”

Mae Jonghak let out a quiet sigh.

“But I’ve known nothing but the sword my entire life. That’s how I came by the empty title of Sword Saint.”

“It’s precisely because you are the Sword Saint that everyone will trust and follow you.”

“Being a martial artist is different from being a leader. I never even became the Sect Leader of a single faction.”

“It’s not that you couldn’t. You chose not to.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox was right.

When the Great Faction War ended and Huashan’s former Sect Leader passed away, every disciple of Huashan had been certain that Sword Saint Mae Jonghak would become their new Sect Leader.

“But you refused. In the end, the Sect Leader’s Command Token went to your Disciple, Heavenly Sword True Person.”

“It was only natural. He was more suited to becoming Huashan’s Sect Leader than I was. And…”

Mae Jonghak ran his fingers over the treasured sword at his waist before continuing.

“I simply liked the sword.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox gazed quietly at Mae Jonghak, then suddenly spoke.

“I don’t know if I ever told you this.”

“Told me what?”

“That person once struggled with the same concern.”

“If you mean that person… surely you’re talking about the Martial God?”

The Thousand-Faced Fox gave a small nod.

“To the people of the world, that person seemed perfect in every way.”

“I know. The Martial God excelled at everything. No—he was overwhelming.”

“But he was a person too. And in the end, he succeeded. For some reason, these old eyes see the two of you overlapping.”

“…!”

Mae Jonghak went still. For a while, he said nothing, gazing at the old martial artist who stood straight before him. Then he spoke.

“Great Hero Song.”

“Yes?”

“It truly is… a fine day.”

“The sky is clear.”

"May I ask the time?"

"It is the wu hour.[2478] Everyone is waiting for one person."

"I'm late."

"You're not late. This is only the beginning."

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak turned his head. Powerful sunlight poured through the wide-open window.

Yes. It truly is a fine day.

He repeated the words to himself. After taking in the blue sky, he slowly turned around.

At that moment, the Thousand-Faced Fox realized that the young man before him was no longer merely a martial artist.

"Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion."

The quiet voice pierced Song Ho's ears.

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion answered directly to the Alliance Leader's Hall, and only one person had the authority to command its chief.

Song Ho took a deep breath and clasped his hands.

"Song Ho, Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion. I await the Alliance Leader's command."

Mae Jonghak's next words marked the beginning of the New Murim Alliance—and its new Alliance Leader's first order.

"Let's go raise the flag."

The old martial artist's eyelids trembled. Then he answered with a cry as strong as any young man's.

"As you command!"

I looked up at the sky. The sun had climbed high into the blue and was pouring down fierce sunlight.

Not even a cool breeze stirred. One thought flashed through my mind.

It's hot.

The heat was intense, but I wasn't uncomfortably warm.

That wasn't just because I'd become Unaffected by Cold and Heat after reaching the Supreme Peak realm.

It wasn't the sunlight I could feel now. It was the heat rising from the crowd—the aura pouring off countless people.

Sssss.

[2478] The wu hour is a traditional two-hour period running approximately from 11 a.m. to 1 p.m.

Below the high platform, so many martial artists stood gathered that I couldn't begin to count them. Their combined aura seemed to have stopped even the wind.

Qi rose from them like a heat haze, burning hotter and fiercer than the sunlight overhead.

Then, through that heat, the person everyone had been waiting for finally appeared.

Thud. Thud.

His firm footsteps reached every ear. The sound alone was enough to make bodies tense and minds snap to attention.

The wandering martial artist who had caused a drunken disturbance only yesterday swallowed hard. So did the orthodox and unorthodox martial artists who had gotten into a brawl with each other.

All because of one man's presence.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

The One God, Three Saints, and Ten Kings.

If the Nine Sects and One Gang[2479] and the Five Great Families were the fifteen pillars supporting the world, then the people bearing those titles were the heroes who had made that world anew.

Ten kings stood upon the earth. Above them stretched the unreachable sky of the Martial God, adorned with three stars.

And…

The brightest star of them all.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak. The Number One Sword Under Heaven.

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

Thousands of martial artists parted at once.

No cheers or exclamations could be heard.

Some were stunned by Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's youthful appearance, while others shuddered at the overwhelming aura they could feel against their skin. But not one dared voice a question or say anything aloud.

No. They couldn't doubt him.

This was a path meant for one person alone.

Mae Jonghak passed through the ranks and ascended the high platform. Standing there like a giant, he swept his calm gaze over the crowd.

"You've all been waiting a long time."

The platform was reserved for a select few.

[2479] The Nine Sects and One Gang is a traditional grouping of major martial arts sects and the Beggars' Gang.

Sect Leaders of prestigious great sects, Family Heads of great families, and heroes and masters who had earned great fame regardless of their origins. They were the people who belonged here.

Jeok Cheongang, the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and I are among them.

But if those on the platform were the pillars of the new Murim Alliance, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was its foundation and its head.

Without anyone taking the lead, we all rose from our seats and clasped our hands toward him.

Dozens of us spoke at once, our voices so perfectly matched they sounded like one.

"We greet the Alliance Leader."

Everyone paid their respects with solemn faces—even Jeok Cheongang and Cheongpung, seated on either side of me.

Mae Jonghak gave us a faint smile, nodded, and turned away.

The next moment, every martial artist below—thousands of them, perhaps even ten thousand—heard his voice clearly.

It shook heaven and earth.

"Peace is over."

"…!"

The air surrounding us burst apart.

A towering tree trembled, and the heroes gathered below the platform froze like statues.

Mae Jonghak continued, his words carrying an extraordinary force of internal energy. Nothing remained of the eccentric man I'd known until now.

"War has already begun. Another hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path are approaching the Central Plains."

Some in the crowd had never lived through the Great Faction War, but none were ignorant of its horrors.

Fear and anger filled the eyes of the older martial artists. The younger ones trembled at a feeling they could not name.

"Dharma King Hong Dao."

At Mae Jonghak's next words, the monks of Shaolin softly murmured Buddhist invocations.

"Poison King Tang Taesang. And the Heaven-Shaking Venerable Nun of Emei."

Tang Sadok, the Myriad-Poison Asura, had made the long journey despite his ailing body. His green eyes gleamed, while the nuns of Emei Sect wept.

"The bloodshed that began in Shanxi Province spread to Henan, then reached Sichuan and Hubei."

Countless lives had been lost in little more than a year.

Old martial artists praised by all and young greenhorns alike had fallen before their lives could fully bloom.

Eight Spring Gorge.

I could still see it whenever I closed my eyes.

How many people had died in that narrow gorge in Shanxi Province?

Who had fallen in Henan, Sichuan, and Hubei?

I didn't know their names or the dreams they'd held while they were alive.

But I knew why they had taken up their swords.

To protect something precious.

Boom!

An unprecedented aura burst from Mae Jonghak's entire body.

Purple qi rooted in the Zaha Divine Technique rolled over his shoulders like waves.

"Take up your weapons and fight back."

His manner of speaking and his aura weren't the only things that had changed.

Right now, before he was the Sword Saint or the Number One Sword Under Heaven, Mae Jonghak was the Alliance Leader guiding us all.

"For the sake of the families who share our blood. For the sake of the Senior Brothers and fellow disciples, and the sects with which we have shared joy and hardship. And…"

A mighty shout erupted from his lips.

"To protect the Murim in which we live, take up your weapons!"

The giant roared. A shiver ran up my spine.

The martial artists filling the grounds let out the breaths they'd been holding and raised a thunderous cheer.

"Waaaaaah!"

"For the destruction of the Demonic Path!"

Shhk, chakachachang!

The world flooded with light. Countless weapons flashed in the sunlight pouring down overhead.

"Waaaaaah!"

"For justice and chivalry!"

Shhk, chakachachang!

The world flooded with light. Countless weapons flashed in the sunlight pouring down overhead.

Mae Jonghak gazed at the dazzling, magnificent sight, then grasped the enormous flag lying at his feet.

Murim Alliance.

Those three characters had been written across it in bold, flowing strokes. Once he raised the flag, a new era would begin.

But what he did next caught everyone by surprise.

“Great Hero Jeok. Would you help me?”

“…!”

I could feel the crowd’s agitation against my skin. Jeok Cheongang, who had been silently staring at Mae Jonghak, suddenly spoke.

“Is the flag heavy?”

“It seems to be, for now.”

“That flag feels heavy even to this old man. And the more hands, the better.”

I knew what I had to do.

At Jeok Cheongang’s signal, Cheongpung and I stepped forward and took hold of the flag together.

Then we pulled it upright with all our strength.

The Murim Alliance had been born.

Chapter 526

“Waaaaaaah!”

Boom! Boom! Boom!

A thunderous roar swallowed everything.

Thousands of martial artists shouted with internal energy behind their voices. Their fierce fighting spirit roused tranquil Mount Song, and their cries echoed without end.

A flag flew high above them. Each had a different name, a different nature, a different life. They were men and women from every walk of life, but now they stood beneath the same banner.

Murim Alliance.

Those three words were all that had been written across the pure white cloth.

The flag was neither as splendid as an emperor’s nor as enormous as the Demonic Cult’s standard had been when its army invaded the Central Plains.

But it was enough.

Everything was contained within those three words: Murim Alliance.

Now the martial artists of the Central Plains would become one beneath that flag. In the new era they had opened for themselves, they would fight a new enemy.

And…

“A new hero will be born.”

The quiet mutter came from somewhere.

From atop a towering tree now thick with leaves, Mungyeong watched the scene below. His gaze came to rest on one person.

Jin Taekyung.

Mungyeong could see the fire in the young man’s eyes as he stood like an iron tower, holding the flag.

With two giants—the Sword Saint and the Fire King—and another rising star, Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung, beside him, Taekyung received the cheers raining down from every direction.

He already looked every bit a hero.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung!”

The martial artists chanted the name of the young hero holding the Murim Alliance’s flag.

As Mungyeong watched, another quiet murmur escaped him.

“It’s finally beginning.”

A new era. A new enemy. And new heroes.

At last, the curtain had risen on a stage long closed.

Some would fall on nameless fields and never rise again. Others would carve their names into a page of Murim's long history.

Life and death. Humiliation and glory.

Right here, on Mount Song, the prelude to a massive war for the world was beginning.

The world trembled. No—it was undergoing a tremendous upheaval.

Until something happened, it was only rumor, no more real than fiction. But once it became reality, its impact was enormous.

The Mount Song Resolution.

On a warm spring day, news spread far and wide that the Nine Sects and One Gang, the Five Great Families, and countless other Murim factions had finally gathered beneath a single flag.

It meant that a fierce war to decide who would rule the world had begun.

"Sect Leader, they say the Murim Alliance has been founded in Henan!"

"Send a messenger pigeon immediately. Our sect will gladly stand beneath the Murim Alliance's flag."

"Yes, Sect Leader!"

"Send word to the other Sect Leaders in Fujian as well. We need to meet."

The world was vast, with more sects and families than anyone could count.

Those who had been unable to make the journey to Henan for one reason or another declared their intention to join the Murim Alliance. Martial artists without a sect chose their own paths.

"Great Hero Jang, come to Henan with me. Shouldn't we join the Murim Alliance?"

"I'm sorry, but I intend to go to Sichuan. You'll have to travel to Henan without me, Great Hero Gwak."

"Huh. Qingcheng and Emei may still stand, but if Dark Heaven heads to Sichuan first, as the Demonic Cult once did, the region could become a demon-slaying battleground."

"That is precisely why I must go to Sichuan. Shouldn't I lend whatever aid I can?"

Some carried the words *righteous chivalry* in their hearts.

"Brother, it sounds as though we're headed the same way. Let's travel together."

"You're a true hero. May I ask your name?"

"My name? Never mind that. I'm just a wandering martial artist who makes his living by the sword, so spare me that embarrassing 'hero' business. I don't know how strong these Dark Heaven bastards are, but if I kill enough of them, I'll make a name for myself and earn a decent sum."

Others took up their weapons, driven by competitive spirit and dreams of making a name for themselves.

Among those who belonged to no particular sect and set out for their own reasons were unfamiliar faces—people who had not appeared in Murim for years, or had never appeared at all.

“What brings you out here, Master?”

“The weather was pleasant, so I came out for some air. But you look troubled. What happened?”

“Well, I was wandering through the mountains looking for snow ginseng to give you, Master, when I met a herb gatherer. He told me that…”

Rumors that the Murim Alliance would be restored in Henan had spread well before the Mount Song Resolution.

News of Murim’s affairs reached even the reclusive masters who had withdrawn from the world into remote mountains and deep valleys.

“Hmm. Dark Heaven and the Murim Alliance…”

“They say everything below the mountain is in an uproar. The Murim Alliance has declared war on Dark Heaven, and the common people are trembling with fear.”

“Hah. After a long peace, calamity has come.”

“Master, what should we do?”

“Countless people will die, as they did during the Great Faction War. Prepare at once, before it’s too late. We’re going to Henan.”

An old master who had spent his remaining years in a nameless valley set out for the Central Plains with his Disciple.

“Old Master, did you catch much today?”

“Bah. The fish aren’t biting worth a damn.”

“Haha. You’ve been saying that for forty years. I caught a few carp. Take some home to eat.”

“Of course I will. I saved your father’s life ten years ago, didn’t I? Give me a big, plump one.”

“All right. Since this is the last time, take them all.”

“Hmm? The last time? What kind of nonsense is that?”

“Haven’t you heard? They say a great calamity has come to Murim.”

“A calamity? Tell me more.”

“They say something called the Murim Alliance has been formed in Henan, and that it’s going to fight Dark Heaven, which is said to be the successor to that Demonic Cult. No one knows what might happen, so I was going to take my family and leave for a while… Old Master? What are you doing?”

“Can’t you see? I’m getting ready to leave.”

“Where are you going? Wait, you’re leaving your fishing rod?”

“I don’t think I’ll need it anymore. You keep it.”

“Old Master! Old Master!”

“We’ll meet again someday. Stay safe.”

The white-haired old man who had spent his days beside a secluded lake departed with a spear on his back instead of a fishing rod.

Some of the old martial artists who had once dominated an era—or some of the reclusive masters from remote valleys who had devoted their entire lives to the single character *martial*—stepped back into the secular world and flowed into the wider world.

“Is this the Murim Alliance?”

“It is. But if you’ve come to join, we can’t let you in right away. You’ll need to go to that pavilion and provide your sobriquet, your name, and something to prove your identity…”

“Then I’ve come to the right place. Go tell them Hong Jeok is here.”

“Hong Jeok, Red Turbans,[2480] whatever you call yourself, you still have to go through verification… Wait. What did you just say?”

“Hong Jeok. Hong Jeok of Guangxi.”

“Th-the Fist King…!”

Names swept away by the waves of time, sobriquets that had vanished from sight.

And yet, despite everything, titles clearly etched into the memories of ordinary people began appearing everywhere.

Even when the sun set and darkness fell, their presence shone like torches.

And rumors of the newly risen stars continued to pass from mouth to mouth.

“I’ll guarantee the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes will play a major role in this war.”

At the middle-aged man’s words, the narrow-eyed man snorted. The speaker had a chin shaped like a spatula.

“What a joke. Call them the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes or the finest young prodigies in the martial world, but weren’t they picked from the disciples and heirs of prestigious sects and families?”

“And? What’s your point?”

“They’re hothouse flowers. How much good will people raised in comfort be on a battlefield?”

Spatula Chin narrowed his eyes.

“Listen to this fellow. Are you with Dark Heaven?”

“What!”

Bird Eyes bristled and shouted.

[2480] The Red Turbans were red-turbaned rebel groups in Chinese history. The guard invokes their name because it sounds similar to Hong Jeok’s.

“They say even a crooked mouth ought to speak straight. Don’t say something that could get me killed! Why would I be with Dark Heaven?”

“Then why are you putting down the pillars of our orthodox faction?”

“Putting them down? I’m just stating the facts! It’s not as though I can shave down your chin!”

“What does my chin have to do with this? Why are you insulting my looks?”

Fire blazed in Spatula Chin’s eyes.

“Say one more word about my chin and you’ll regret it. Got that?”

“Spatula Chin! That chin takes my breath away! Chin-chin, ka-thunk-thunk-chin!”

“You fucking bastard!”

Crash! Crack!

The table overturned, sending side dishes and liquor bottles tumbling to the floor.

A sword fight seemed ready to break out at any moment. Watching Bird Eyes and Spatula Chin square off, a man with a goatee spoke with measured dignity.

“You’re both wrong.”

Bird Eyes and Spatula Chin turned toward him together.

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“I’ll rip out every hair of that beard.”

“…”

The goateed man shook his head and continued.

“I don’t doubt the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes will distinguish themselves. But compared with the strength Dark Heaven has shown so far, they’re still only young prodigies.”

Bird Eyes brightened.

“So I’m right?”

“To a degree.”

“I knew it. You’ve got uncommon insight. Your beard looks especially fine today.”

“…”

Spatula Chin ground his teeth and glared at Bird Eyes.

“Your eyes are smaller than your asshole, and now you’re deaf too? Did you already forget he said *both* of us were wrong?”

“…Fair point. But why? I don’t see what’s wrong with what I said.”

The goateed man stroked his beard as he answered.

“There are genuine talents everywhere. You’re right that the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes grew up in the best possible conditions. But that doesn’t change the fact that they’re the finest young prodigies in the martial world.”

“Hm. And?”

“Nor are they all disciples of prestigious sects. Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword and Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, is a prime example.”

“Ah, I forgot about the Heaven Shaking Sword.”

Spatula Chin, who had been waiting for an opening, cut in with a mocking grin.

“The Heaven Shaking Sword is impressive, but Murong Yeonghwi, a blood relative of the Murong Family, is overwhelming too. Still, what could a nobody like you possibly know?”

“What did you say, you bastard? If you fell in the water, that chin would float…”

The two began growling at each other again. The goateed man sighed deeply.

“Stop fighting and listen. The young prodigies to watch aren’t the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes. The Two Dragons stand above them.”

Bird Eyes and Spatula Chin froze.

Even they had to admit he was right. The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes could not compare with those two Divine Dragons: Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung and Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung.

“Certainly…”

“That’s true.”

They nodded despite themselves. Then a question occurred to them.

“What are those two doing right now?”

“Who knows? But one thing is certain.”

The goateed man continued, his expression solemn.

“They must be doing something extraordinary.”

Cheongpung spoke with a stiff expression.

“Ahh, I want dumplings!”

“…”

Don’t say it so loudly, you idiot.

Chapter 527

Seven days and nights had passed since the day people called the Mount Song Resolution.

Amid the shouts of countless Murim heroes, the Murim Alliance's flag had been raised once more. News that the Alliance had officially been restored for the first time in decades swept beyond Henan and shook the entire Murim world.

Things have been moving at a frantic pace.

At first, I'd thought there was no reason for me to be particularly busy. I learned how naïve that was less than half a day after the Murim Alliance was formed.

"Captain. I hear there's a visitor downstairs."

"What do you mean, you *hear* there's a visitor?"

"Apparently Cheongpung ran into him on his way back from buying dumplings. He says the man's waiting downstairs."

"I suddenly want dumplings. And I'm not meeting him."

"I caught a glimpse of him. He looked like someone important."

"What, am I some lowborn bastard? Send our important guest home with all due courtesy."

"How could I do that? I hear he made an appointment."

"What the hell are you talking about? I haven't made any appointments since I got here. And how many people do I even know?"

"That's true. You don't have any friends, Captain."

"Really? Because it looks like you're about to lose your head."

"Hmm. Maybe he spoke with the Lesser Family Head?"

"This bastard doesn't even flinch anymore."

"Spend three years as Hyuk Mujin, and you wind up with about three lives."

"Enough nonsense. Send him back. Ah, but who exactly is this important person?"

"Oh, wait a moment. I'll go ask."

"Go on."

Hyuk Mujin went downstairs at a leisurely pace, then came racing back.

"K-K-Kongtong Sect! The Kongtong Sect Leader!"

"Bring him in at once! Bring him innnn!"

Wait, why is hyung[2481] here?

Starting with the Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, a steady stream of renowned figures of Murim came to visit.

[2481] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

The Family Head of the Namgung Family, whom I already knew, came in person. People from sects and families I'd formed connections with while traveling across the Murim world arrived one after another.

Of course, far more of them came to make a new connection.

"Captain."

"…Who is it this time?"

"The Shandong Yue Family. The Family Head came in person."

"…Receive him with due courtesy."

"A representative from the Murim world of Guizhou was sent as well…"

"…Bring him in as well."

"Oh, and Captain."

"…Bring him in."

I hadn't realized I was this famous. No, to be precise, I hadn't realized I was *this* famous.

After three days of meeting one visitor after another, I was exhausted.

Fuck, I can't keep doing this.

It would be one thing if these were blind dates with pretty women.

But dealing with more than ten middle-aged and old men every day left me feeling like my soul had been sucked out. By then, the smell of tea alone made me nauseous, and the conversations across those teacups were mostly the same.

"Oh! So you're the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon I've heard so much about!"

The Jin Taekyung Conversation Guide.

Had they all read a book with that title before coming? Every one of them opened with the same line.

But even an obedient child eventually gets contrary. At first, I'd forced a smile and exchanged meaningless pleasantries. As time went on, I got more honest.

"I've heard many rumors about you."

"I've heard plenty of stories about myself too."

"A young hero has appeared in Murim. It's truly wonderful. Ho ho ho."

"I'm the happiest person of all. Ha ha ha."

"Incidentally, I have a daughter of marriageable age…"

"I have two older brothers of marriageable age."

"Good heavens, man! How dare you spring your daughter on him out of nowhere? Have you lost your mind? Young Hero Jin, don't pay that fellow any mind."

"It's all right. I wasn't listening anyway."

"Then listen to me instead."

"Wow. So that's where this is going."

"As a matter of fact, I have a daughter too. I'm sure you'll like her."

"I'll stake Hyuk Mujin's balls that I won't."

"What are you talking about? Balls—no, what man in the world would turn down a beauty?"

"A beauty? Is your daughter very pretty?"

"Do you even have to ask? Her beauty is already famous throughout Fujian!"

"Oh. Ohhh."

"Everyone knows her! Stop anyone passing by and ask. She's already pretty, but in five years, she'll surely be the First Beauty of Fujian!"

"Ohhh, the First Beauty of Fujian… Wait. Why five years?"

"She's twelve."

"Get out."

I could hardly remember how those seven days and nights had passed.

Some of my visitors already knew me, while others came out of simple curiosity. Most, though, wanted to forge some kind of connection with me or the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

And not all of them were martial artists.

"Captain. Someone from a place called Central Plains Commerce is asking to see you."

"Bring them in—no, wait. Why is a trading company looking for me? My eldest brother, maybe, but me?"

"I'm not sure why. But I have an eye for people, and they don't seem bad. It might be worth meeting them."

"Hey."

"Y-Yes?"

"You bastard. Central Plains Commerce slipped you money, didn't they?"

"Gasp! H-How did you know?"

"Give back every last bit and send them away. While I'm still asking nicely."

Now there were even people slipping bribes to Hyuk Mujin.

Most of the visitors so far had arranged their appointments through Jin Wikyung, so I'd met them reluctantly. They knew full well he was the only way to get an appointment with me. Anyone who came directly fell into one of two categories.

Either Jin Wikyung would turn them away for some disqualifying reason, or their standing was so high they could show up whenever they pleased.

The first was far more common. Those people usually tried some shallow trick, then left without so much as seeing my face.

Why were they going to such lengths? I had a pretty good idea why all this attention had suddenly fallen on me.

The flag, obviously.

On the day the Murim Alliance was officially proclaimed, I'd raised its flag together with Mae Jonghak, the new Alliance Leader, Jeok Cheongang, and Cheongpung.

It had moved me, but I hadn't thought much more of it. To everyone else who'd witnessed it, apparently, it had been an enormous culture shock.

I suppose it makes sense. Two young punks got the spotlight instead of all those elders.

The platform had been packed with people from prestigious sects and families, including the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

Murim had reached such an extreme level of population aging that the platform could have passed for a senior center. Even the men in their forties who'd managed to get up there were little more than pu'er tea[2482] runners. Yet Cheongpung and I, barely past twenty, had the audacity to take part in that glorious, historic moment.

The sight had clearly startled everyone. Some nodded, acknowledging the ability and qualifications of those two young punks. Others seemed to find it deeply irritating.

The Zhongnan Sect, for example.

I couldn't be sure, but their guts were probably twisted with resentment by now. After all, the Jin Family of Taiyuan and I had begun rising rapidly, and our history with them was anything but friendly.

The bad blood had started with the Three Hands of Zhongnan, the three idiots of the Zhongnan Sect. It had worsened when the Roaring Fury Swordsman came to the Jin Family of Taiyuan's New Year's Day banquet and caused a scene, only to be beaten by Jeok Cheongang like a dog on the hottest day of summer.

And that wasn't all. The feud had reached its peak when the Taeeul Merciless Sword, regarded alongside the Sect Leader Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord as the Zhongnan Sect's greatest master, was defeated by me.

After that much humiliation, seeing me in the spotlight must have made them grind their teeth. For all I knew, they were somewhere right now biting, tearing, and chewing on me, the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and Jeok Cheongang.

Given the personalities of the Zhongnan Sect's people I had seen so far, I could almost believe it if they joined hands with Dark Heaven.

Hey, Zhongnan Sect.

Dark Heaven! Come on in.

The Murim Alliance has been formed. Why the long faces?

Jin Taekyung is pissing us off. That fucking brat.

Ho ho ho. Want a hit of a Temporary Strength Pill?

Sure. Roll me one.

[2482] Pu'er is a fermented tea from Yunnan, China.

I could picture it. I really could.

Still, Zhongnan was a venerable orthodox sect and one of the Nine Sects and One Gang. Surely they weren't crazy enough to join hands with Dark Heaven. But they'd find some way to get in our way at every turn.

Hang on. This isn't fair. Why is everyone swarming me?

At the thought, I looked toward the rice weevil—or rather, the dumpling grub—fidgeting in a corner with Mimi-chan.[2483]

"Why, Benefactor?"

"Good heavens, the bug talks."

"Pardon?"

"Nothing. But Cheongpung, why do you look so free? Doesn't anyone come to see you?"

"I don't meet people when I'm full. And I don't meet them if they don't bring me something tasty."

I thought about that for a moment, then asked, "Aren't you always full?"

"Yes. So I don't meet anyone."

"…Right."

Must be nice not having a care in the world.

If I had to pick the person in all Murim who gave the fewest fucks and did exactly as he pleased, Cheongpung would be a strong contender.

Even on the day of the Mount Song Resolution, he'd bounced around in delight because it was his first time raising the Murim Alliance's flag.

Is he a genius or a lunatic?

Probably both. Hmm.

As I was thinking that, Cheongpung yawned and spoke.

"And I'm not free. I'm training right now."

"What fresh bullshit is this?"

"I'm serious. Look."

Cheongpung took Mimi, the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, off his shoulder and began squirming in his seat.

"…Sorry to interrupt, but are you evolving into a bug?"

"No. It's martial arts."

"Martial arts?"

"Yes. I made it after watching Mimi move."

Then why did it look nothing like martial arts?

I asked with complete sincerity.

[2483] The Japanese suffix *-chan* is an affectionate form of address.

“Please tell me this martial art isn’t called Squirming. Or Toughening Up. Something like that.”

“No. It’s a footwork technique.”

“…Then you should stand up and do it, you idiot.”

“Oh, right. I forgot.”

Did I really have to tell him that?

While I was at a loss for words, Cheongpung sprang to his feet and took a step.

Or rather, the moment I felt him take a step, his figure disappeared.

Whoosh!

With a faint sound, Cheongpung reached the far end of the spacious room and flashed me a toothy grin.

“Ta-da. What do you think?”

“…!”

What did I just see?

Goose bumps shot up my back.

His movement was ghostlike—no, snakelike. It was unmistakably a footwork technique, and yet it wasn’t.

Cheongpung hadn’t walked. He’d slid, so fast that even I could barely follow him with my eyes.

“I mixed Mimi’s movements with a few different martial arts. Moving like this makes me feel like I’m Mimi too, and I like it!”

“…You mixed them?”

“Yes! It’s called Mimi Step! Would you like to learn it, Benefactor?”

He really is insane. In more ways than one.

I stared at Cheongpung with my mouth hanging open, then shook my head.

“No. I don’t want to.”

“Aww…”

Just as Cheongpung’s shoulders drooped, Hyuk Mujin’s voice came from outside the door.

“Captain. There’s a visitor here.”

A visitor? Was there anyone else left who could come see me?

Chapter 528

Creak.

It didn’t take long to recognize the uninvited guest.

The moment I saw the familiar face come through the door, I spoke without hesitation.

“Hey, Hyuk Mujin. Who told you to let a beggar in?”

“Have you been—listen to this damn bastard.”

Gung Gibang, who had been grinning brightly despite his grimy face, scowled.

“I go out of my way to make time for you, and that’s how you greet me?”

“I called a beggar a beggar. What’s the problem?”

“Do you ever think about how it feels to be the beggar hearing it?”

“No. Not for a single second.”

“…You’re worse than a scorpion. One day, a hundred thousand Beggars’ Sect disciples will surround you and beat the hell out of you.”

I shrugged.

“Not likely. I’m a pretty valuable asset to the Murim Alliance.”

“I swear on my begging bowl, when the time comes, you’ll be the first one I beat senseless.”

“That’s fine too. It’ll mean the war is over.”

“You mean that?”

“Yeah. Promise.”

Gung Gibang glared at me in silence. Then his gaze softened, and a faint smile appeared on his lips.

“Damn it. The war’s barely begun, and already I want it to be over.”

“What, so you can beat me up?”

Gung Gibang gave a quiet laugh and shook his head.

“I may be destined to beg for the rest of my life, but I’m not stupid enough to think that way. No matter what, war must never happen.”

“You could distinguish yourself in battle and become a hero.”

“What would a beggar like me do with being a hero?”

“Oh.”

A wise answer to a stupid question.

I’d asked because I wanted to know what he really thought. I gave him a sincere round of applause.

Clap, clap, clap.

“What are you doing?”

“Nothing. Just thinking how our Gibang’s all grown up, having thoughts like that.”

"…What exactly do you think of me? And you're younger than I am. How can you be so shameless?"

"If getting older made everyone mature, the world would be a much nicer place. Time passes without anyone having to work at it."

In that sense, Gung Gibang's thinking really was remarkably sound for someone his age in Murim.

This wasn't the twenty-first-century modern world. This was Murim, where the primal law of the strong devouring the weak held sway.

It would be naive to think every martial artist now filling Henan had joined the Murim Alliance out of chivalry alone.

Especially the younger ones.

They were at an age when their blood ran hot.

Then again, middle-aged martial artists nearing forty weren't much different. To them, the Great Faction War was little more than a trace of a past that had ended before they were born.

Plenty of people in the generations that had never known war were driven less by chivalry than by dreams of winning glory and becoming heroes.

That went for wandering martial artists who acted as if there were no tomorrow, and for disciples of the great sects and families too.

I get it. It's the times we live in, and it's how Murim works…

But however generously I tried to look at them, they still looked like fucking idiots to me.

Thank heavens more people had joined the Murim Alliance out of chivalry than for reasons like theirs.

Come to think of it, the people around me are pretty normal by comparison. Hmm.

Just then, Cheongpung slid forward like a snake and appeared right in front of Gung Gibang.

Ssss—

"Agh! What the fuck?"

"Hehe. This is the new footwork technique I made, Mimi Step. It really looks like Mimi, doesn't it?"

"Like Mimi, my ass. It looks like a dog! Like a damn beggar!"

At Gung Gibang's shriek, Hyuk Mujin spoke with the happiest expression in the world.

"Young Hero Cheongpung, could you do that one more time later?"

"Wow! Of course I can!"

"No, you can't! Absolutely not! Don't do it!"

"…"

Normal, my ass.

Put them together and it was hard to find a bigger bunch of fucking idiots.

Ah, my head hurts.

I rubbed my throbbing temple and asked the question I'd put off.

"Anyway, what are you here for?"

Gung Gibang shot Cheongpung a wary glance before answering.

"There are a few people who want to meet you and Cheongpung. I thought I'd stop by and ask, just in case."

"Of course there are plenty of people who want to meet me."

"…You're obnoxious, but I can't argue with that."

"So who are they?"

Gung Gibang sighed.

"The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes."

"The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?"

"The ones you know. Not all of them—about half."

Well, obviously it was the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes I knew. Were there others?

The moment I heard the name, I'd made up my mind.

"No. What would I meet them for?"

"To get acquainted. It can't hurt for young prodigies to be on good terms."

"Can't see how it would help, either. And young prodigies, my ass. Don't put me in the same league as you lot."

Gung Gibang stared at me in disbelief.

"…How can you say something that offensive with a straight face?"

"Because everyone knows it's true."

"Well, yes, but… Damn it. Fine. What about Cheongpung?"

Realizing he wasn't going to get anywhere with me, Gung Gibang quickly changed targets.

Sssssss—

Cheongpung had been closely observing Mimi, the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake, who had somehow turned into a giant snake while drawing everyone's attention. Without even turning around, he answered.

"Hmm. I don't want to go."

"Even though they've laid out a lavish feast for you?"

"I ate dumplings earlier, so I'm full. I don't think I'd go even if I were hungry."

"You could take the food with you. Eat it when you get hungry."

"I don't know. I haven't had much of an appetite lately."

"Wh-what?"

Gung Gibang stared at him as if he'd been stabbed.

Hyuk Mujin and I were just as shocked.

What the hell? Is he really insane?

Captain, did I hear that wrong?

No. You heard him right. He said he has no appetite.

That bastard isn't Cheongpung. He's definitely a Dark Heaven spy.

That's… convincing!

Hyuk Mujin and I carried on a silent conversation with our eyes.

That was how shocking Cheongpung's announcement was.

Cheongpung, of all people, has no appetite?

It was news as astonishing as the founding of the New Murim Alliance. Yet Cheongpung didn't so much as flinch beneath the astonished stares of everyone around him.

"Anyway, I'm fine. You go ahead, Benefactor."

"Huh? Uh, no. I'm not going either."

"Really? Hehe. Then I'll get back to what I was doing. I think Mimi Step needs a few improvements."

I had no idea why he was acting like this, but one thing seemed certain.

As time passed and the circumstances around him changed, some kind of change had begun in Cheongpung as well.

That guy…

I stared at Cheongpung in silence, then turned toward Gung Gibang.

"Anyway, you'd better get going."

"Mm. I suppose so. We talked so long I'm late for our meeting."

Still sneaking stunned glances at Cheongpung, Gung Gibang turned away and muttered, "They'll be disappointed. Young Lady Ju seemed especially excited."

"Disappointed? I've already met some of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes at the Star-Array Grand Banquet. I'm bound to run into the others again sooner or later —"

I broke off. The last thing Gung Gibang had said had taken over my thoughts.

"Wait. Who?"

"Huh? Who do you mean?"

"You said someone was especially excited."

"Oh. Young Lady Ju?"

So I hadn't misheard.

"By Young Lady Ju, do you mean…?"

"Of course I mean the Young Lady Ju you know. Young Lady Ju Hwaran of the Yongbong Escort Bureau—the Young Bureau Head, the Dagger Hidden Flower."

"…!"

A memory came back to me.

In Murim, it had been only two or three months ago, yet somehow it felt impossibly distant.

Ironically, it was also one of the clearest memories left behind by all that time.

“The moon is so bright tonight.”

Yes. The moon had been unusually bright that night.

Or perhaps the moon hadn’t been the brightest thing there. Perhaps it had been someone’s face.

I hadn’t been looking at the moon then.

“Great Hero Jin.”

“Yes, Young Lady Ju.”

“Do you think I can do it?”

I could almost hear her voice again, damp and desolate, drifting through the flower-filled garden.

What had I told her?

I thought for a moment before muttering blankly,

“…It’s all right even if you can’t.”

“What? What’s all right?”

I came back to myself.

The soft moonlight, the scent of flowers, the voice—all of it vanished. Even the face that had hovered before my eyes faded away.

I looked up to find Gung Gibang right in front of me, wearing a puzzled expression.

A small sigh escaped me.

“Gibang.”

“Mm?”

“Why are you so ugly?”

“…?”

“I’m sorry, but I mean it. Actually, I don’t think I’m all that sorry. Things were going so well.”

Gung Gibang’s ugly face contorted.

“You little bastard, you’ve been doing this since—”

“Enough.”

I shook my head, cutting him off.

“Let’s go.”

“What?”

“Stop asking and let’s go meet the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes or whoever they are. Hearing about that feast made me hungry.”

“Uh, uh-huh?”

Gung Gibang forgot to be angry. He blinked at me, then nodded hurriedly.

"Uh, sure. They'll all be glad to see you."

I didn't much care who would be glad.

It was just… well, how should I put it?

I just felt like seeing her after all this time.

Yes. That was all. Besides, I owed her thanks for something concerning Jeok Cheongang. I had every reason to go.

It's only right. Anyone decent would go.

Muttering that to myself, I started walking. Gung Gibang's shout that he was coming with me rang noisily from behind.

The three-story inn was large and lavish. Between its size and its prices, anyone without money to spare would have trouble setting foot inside—and, in practice, they didn't.

The three men and one woman seated by a window on its top floor were hardly ordinary people themselves.

"Young Lady Ju, may I pour you a drink?"

"Now, now. The young lady doesn't care much for alcohol. Isn't that right, Young Lady Ju?"

The handsome men in gleaming silk martial uniforms and hero headbands[2484] had no idea what the woman before them was thinking.

When is he coming?

She no longer heard a word they were saying.

At some point, she had stopped leaning back in her chair and begun tilting toward the window instead. Her eyes kept darting between the half-open window and the stairs.

Gung Gibang made such a bold promise. Should I go out and see for myself?

And just as all those worries and thoughts began chasing one another in endless circles—

Jingle.

The bell rang as the inn door opened, and Ju Hwaran sprang to her feet.

[2484] A hero headband (*yeongunggeon*) is a cloth headwrap worn by martial artists in Korean martial-arts fiction.

Chapter 529

Jingle.

“Welcome!”

The inn attendant’s hearty cry followed the ring of the bell above the door.

Ju Hwaran sprang to her feet, hope rising in her chest. But disappointment quickly filled her eyes.

“Ah…”

It wasn’t him. From up here, she couldn’t see the newcomer’s face properly, but she could tell that much.

No—if it had been him, she might have known him by his shadow alone.

It wasn’t him. It wasn’t that person.

Hwaran sighed softly and looked down at the first floor once more, reluctant to look away. Staring wouldn’t change anything, yet she couldn’t quite give up.

The men seated with her cleared their throats at the sight.

“Ahem.”

“Ahem.”

They had been watching Hwaran’s every move from the start. They weren’t foolish enough to miss what her reaction meant.

Three men sat across the table from her. Two of them exchanged a glance—but their eyes weren’t the only things communicating. Their lips barely moved as they spoke through Sound Transmission.

—Fellow Daoist Hwangbo. Who do you think Young Lady Ju is waiting for?

The question came from Baek Woo, the Kunlun Cloud Dragon. Handsome, clear-skinned, and dressed in spotless white, he was widely acknowledged as the Kunlun Sect’s finest young prodigy and was one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

At his Sound Transmission, the beautiful young man with a sharp nose slightly furrowed his brow.

—No idea.

—I can think of only one person. If I’m right, it’s the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Tae—

—Drop it.

Hwangbo Ak, the beautiful young man who had coldly cut him off, was the Lesser Family Head of the Hwangbo Family and another member of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

He was in a foul mood.

To think I, Hwangbo Ak, would be treated as less than some other bastard.

It was unthinkable. For someone as full of himself as Hwangbo Ak, it was especially hard to accept.

The Hwangbo Family might not be one of the Five Great Families, but its name carried considerable weight throughout Murim. No one could deny that it was an old martial family that had ruled Shandong for generations.

And Hwangbo Ak was its Lesser Family Head.

He had the martial talent to earn a place among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, too, and the looks to stand out anywhere. A fine family, immense wealth and prestige, a handsome face—it was only natural that women flocked to him.

The trouble was that, for the first time in nearly thirty years of life, everything he had enjoyed seemed worthless.

The Dagger Hidden Flower, Ju Hwaran.

The moment he saw her, he had realized that all the beautiful women he'd met before were fireflies before the sun.

She wore no makeup, unlike the others, yet her face held a beauty he couldn't describe. Even her plain-colored martial uniform looked more elegant than an ornate court dress.

He had fallen for her at first sight.

Why couldn't I have met a woman like her sooner?

Hwangbo Ak gazed at Hwaran as though entranced. Every small movement she made, every glimmer in her eyes—bright as the morning star—set his heart fluttering and stirred a desire buried deep within him.

But then…

"Phew."

Hwaran sighed again, and his brow tightened.

He knew what lay behind that sigh. He knew who it was for.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

He repeated the epithet and name silently. Beneath the table, his hand clenched of its own accord.

What's so special about that bastard?

He had already heard about Hwaran's connection to Jin Taekyung.

The details of what had happened between the Yongbong Escort Bureau and the Zhongnan Sect two months ago had never become widely known. But word had swept through Murim that the Taeeul Merciless Sword, one of Zhongnan's three greatest masters, had knelt before a young prodigy barely past twenty.

Impossible.

It was something that could not and should not have happened. Hwangbo Ak had dismissed it as a ridiculous rumor and clicked his tongue.

More troubling, though, was his suspicion that the incident had left Hwaran with feelings for Jin Taekyung.

—Are you certain?

Baek Woo perked up at the sudden Sound Transmission.

—Hm?

—I asked whether what you said earlier was certain. The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung. Is the person Young Lady Ju is waiting for really that bastard?

—Do you think she's waiting for the Successor Beggar?

—…

Even Hwangbo Ak had to admit she wasn't.

Whatever peculiar tastes Hwaran might have, she couldn't possibly like Gung Gibang. The man gave off the sour reek of stale dog food just by sitting nearby.

—So it really is that bastard? Are you saying this Young Master is less than a worm that crawled out of some backwater corner of Shanxi Province?

—Not a worm. A Divine Dragon. And Shanxi Province is no longer a backwater corner. It is the hidden residence[2485] from which the dragon named Jin Taekyung rose, as well as the center of the trade routes running through northern Gaoyuan.

Having lightly corrected him, Baek Woo continued.

—Fellow Daoist Hwangbo, this isn't the Jin Family of Taiyuan you used to know. Now that I think about it, I could tell the moment I met the Heaven Shaking Sword.

—The Heaven Shaking Sword? Heaven Shaking Sword Jin Mukyung?

—Is there another Heaven Shaking Sword we both know?

Hwangbo Ak's eyebrows twitched.

If Ju Hwaran, who kept sighing across the table, and that young escort who looked like he had crawled in from who knew where had not been watching him, he would have scowled long ago.

—Don't bring up that name. Do you think I'm asking because I don't know who that bastard is?

—Ah, that's right. You and the Heaven Shaking Sword were at Heaven's Gate Temple together—

—Enough. Stop!

—You startled me. All right. Why are you shouting?

Hwangbo Ak's clenched fist had turned red.

Jin Mukyung. That was a name he would remember until the day he died.

Hwangbo Ak had thought he possessed everything. Jin Mukyung had shown him a wall he could never climb—and humiliated him in the process.

Damn it.

Now the younger brother was standing in his way, too.

Seeing the anger on Hwangbo Ak's face, Baek Woo moved his lips cautiously.

[2485] *Qian di* originally referred to a prince's residence before he ascended the throne. Here it casts Shanxi as the place from which Jin Taekyung rose.

—Fellow Daoist Hwangbo. May I offer you some advice?

—What now?

—You remember what you said to me. If the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon comes, don't ever mention it out loud. No—don't even move your lips.

—Hmph. Worried we might come to blows?

—No, that's not it. I'm worried I might get dragged into it too.

—…What?

Baek Woo regarded him with a look full of concern and pity.

—If you want to die, die alone.

—…!

—You were in closed-door training at your family's estate during the Star-Array Grand Banquet, so you probably don't know. But even now, whenever I think about that man, I feel—ugh. Anyway, keep that in mind. Understood?

What in the world was he talking about? Die alone?

Hwangbo Ak remained silent for a moment, staring at Baek Woo in disbelief. Then he sent another Sound Transmission.

—Are you… serious?

—Infinite Life Buddha.[2486] I swear before the Primordial Heavenly Venerable[2487] that I'm completely serious.

—Have you no pride as a martial artist?

—I lost that at the Star-Array Grand Banquet. Do you know what it's like to have the top of your head stepped on after using the Cloud-Dragon Eight Forms?

—Even so!

—Even so, no. That man is a monster.

—W-What happened to the Kunlun Cloud Dragon, that proud, lofty crane? Where's the Baek Woo I knew?

Baek Woo gazed into the past with a nostalgic look in his eyes.

—Come to think of it, the Successor Beggar said something similar to me back then. Then, in the very next test, he was beaten like a dog by Jin Taekyung. You heard what happened, didn't you? Gung Gibang fell behind in movement technique, his eyes rolled back, and he tried to grab Jin Taekyung by the hair. He nearly got his head knocked off.

—…!

—Infinite Life Buddha.[2488] Let's be honest. Do you think everything the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon has done is just a rumor?

—Of course!

[2486] A Buddhist invocation wishing for immeasurable life.
[2487] A Daoist deity invoked here as a witness to Baek Woo's oath.
[2488] A Buddhist invocation wishing for immeasurable life.

Baek Woo let out a quiet sigh at the firm reply.

—Why?

—How could any man do those things? His master, the Fire King, must have handled everything and given his Disciple the credit!

—True. By any ordinary measure, it's absurd. Reaching Supreme Peak when he's barely past twenty? How could that be possible?

At last, a sensible answer. Hwangbo Ak nodded with conviction.

—Exactly. The Fire King Jeok Cheongang must have stepped in and handed his Disciple the credit.

—I'm saying this again because I'm worried about you: don't tell the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon that his master handed him the credit. I don't want to be paired with you as a battle partner and have my face beaten in.

—…What are you playing at?

—Infinite Life Buddha.[2489] It's simple. Don't try to reason it out with common sense. Don't even try to understand it. Just accept it.

For a moment, Baek Woo's almost enlightened tone left Hwangbo Ak speechless. Then he tried another angle.

—W-Wait. You have feelings for Young Lady Ju too, don't you?

—Young Lady Ju? Of course I like her. What man wouldn't?

—That very Young Lady Ju has feelings for Jin Taekyung. And you still intend to protect your rival?

—My life matters more to me than Young Lady Ju. So does my hair.

—What?

Baek Woo checked that no one was looking, then casually dipped his head.

A strangely bare patch showed between the neatly arranged strands at his crown.

—Infinite Life Buddha.[2490] See?

—What on earth happened to your—

Hwangbo Ak could not finish his Sound Transmission. Baek Woo gave him a sorrowful smile.

—My hair stopped growing after my head was stepped on during the Star-Array Grand Banquet…

—…!

—Give up. Giving up makes life easier. But if you absolutely can't give up, please do it when I'm not around. I'd like to live, too.

What kind of insane nonsense was this?

Hwangbo Ak swallowed hard.

[2489] A Buddhist invocation wishing for immeasurable life.

[2490] A Buddhist invocation wishing for immeasurable life.

He was still furious, but a chill ran down his spine. Baek Woo was an old friend and a proud martial artist. If even *he* was talking like this…

Is this for real?

Hwangbo Ak had never believed all the rumors about the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

But if—if there wasn't a shred of falsehood in them…

A monster beyond common sense.

Yes. An undeniable monster.

And at the same time, an unbearable humiliation wrapped itself around Hwangbo Ak's entire body.

What a damnable mess.

His fist tightened. A groan escaped through his parted teeth, and Hwaran, sensing that something was wrong, spoke.

"Young Hero Hwangbo. Is something wrong?"

"Ah, no. Nothing."

At his strained reply, the young escort who had done nothing but occupy a seat at their table gave a quiet laugh.

"You look very much like something's wrong."

"…I said it's nothing."

"If you say so. The food here is good, by the way."

Hwangbo Ak narrowed his eyes.

He had allowed the man to join them only because he was Hwaran's escort. From his behavior to the way he spoke, everything about him grated on Hwangbo Ak.

A mutter slipped through his twisted lips.

"This is the trouble with people who have no pedigree…"

Ju Hwaran was not a fool. A cold chill passed over her beautiful face, which had been filled with troubled thoughts only a moment earlier.

"Young Hero Hwangbo."

"Ah, I wouldn't want Young Lady Ju to misunderstand. I wasn't talking about that fellow."

Hwangbo Ak put on a false smile and pointed to a table some distance away.

"I was talking about those bastards who practice demonic, heterodox arts over there."

And at the moment his voice, neither loud nor soft, rang through the inn—

Scrape.

Someone rose from their seat.

Chapter 530

Henan truly deserved to be called the Central Plains.

Civilization had begun along the Yellow River, and for thousands of years, Henan had stood at the center of the world. It had been home to the capitals of nine dynasties that rose and fell like wildfire over the ages.

So even now, with the Murim Alliance officially restored and the threat of war hanging in the air, Henan Province had not lost its vitality.

If anything, the opposite was true.

“Is it just me, or are there more people around? The atmosphere seems pretty good, too.”

Hyuk Mujin was right. The broad main street was packed, and there was little sign of serious worry on anyone’s face.

Now and then, someone cast an uneasy glance at a passing martial artist carrying weapons, but that was all.

I pulled my bamboo hat lower. “Yeah, it does.”

“Strange. Until recently, things were pretty grim. Is this the calm before the storm?”

“…You lunatic. Why don’t you pray for something to happen while you’re at it?”

“Considering the situation, I’m not exactly wrong.”

He had a point. But Hyuk Mujin was overlooking something. I considered smacking him upside the head, then shook my head.

“I think those people have realized something.”

“What?”

“That Henan is the safest place in the world.”

“…Ah.”

To ordinary people, martial artists were like wild beasts no one could control.

But most of the martial artists now in Henan had come together under the banners of chivalry, the greater good, and the Murim Alliance. And there weren’t just dozens or hundreds of them. There were thousands.

News of a war among martial artists must have frightened the commoners at first, but people were quickly settling down.

If this were the modern world, they wouldn’t be so relaxed.

Imagine a war breaking out between the United States and Russia.

The moment the war began, the citizens of Moscow or Washington, DC, would either be running for their lives or staring up at the sky, trying to guess when an intercontinental ballistic missile or a nuclear weapon might come flying toward them.

Not that Henan is guaranteed to be safe.

Could Dark Heaven sweep through half the world and reach Henan?

It wasn't impossible. The Murim Alliance had formed, and countless martial artists had gathered beneath one flag, but no one could know how the war would end.

The bigger problem was that Dark Heaven had other ways of getting here.

The Moving Formation. Or should I call it a warp magic circle?

It was a disturbing truth, hard to believe and not yet known to everyone.

A truth like that could make people more vigilant. It could also cause tremendous shock and chaos. That was probably why it hadn't been made public yet.

When that happens, people won't be smiling like this anymore.

I smacked my lips bitterly and looked around.

Children watched passing martial artists with fascination. Merchants were delighted by the unexpected boom. Martial artists moved along the main street, their faces showing a mix of tension and excitement.

None of them, at least, knew everything about Dark Heaven. Those privy to its deeper secrets were already in a meeting with their new Alliance Leader, one that might go on indefinitely.

"Captain?"

"What are you thinking about so hard? You're making people stare."

"…Nothing. Let's go."

I must have spaced out. I started walking again.

Standing still in the middle of a crowded main street was bound to draw attention. Sure enough, a few sharp-eyed people were already looking our way.

They're not ordinary martial artists. They're masters.

That didn't make them Dark Heaven's agents. They wore martial uniforms and carried their weapons openly, and I could sense pure qi from every one of them.

"Captain."

Hyuk Mujin's voice came quietly from behind me. I kept walking as though nothing was wrong.

"It's fine. Just keep going."

"You knew?"

"Of course."

"I'm still worried."

I understood why. Since the Mount Song Resolution, I'd become something of a celebrity.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi and the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon were already epithets firmly imprinted throughout the Murim. But by raising the Murim Alliance's flag before thousands of martial heroes, I had left an even more definite impression.

I wasn't on the level of the heads of the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families, but more people knew my name and face than those of most Elder-level masters from major factions.

"What's there to worry about? Pretend you haven't noticed them and keep walking."

"No, I'm worried something really bad is going to happen."

Gung Gibang clicked his tongue.

"What a tiny little heart you have. What serious thing is going to happen just because they recognize his face? It'll only be annoying. This is exactly why he's wearing that bamboo hat."

He glanced at me. "What's gotten into him?"

"Leave him alone. It's kind of touching that he noticed them first and started worrying."

"…I suppose."

I smiled to myself.

I didn't usually show it, but I had a soft spot for Hyuk Mujin. Since coming to Murim, I'd spent more time with him than anyone else, and we'd been through all kinds of trouble together. Of course I cared about—

"This is driving me crazy. What are you two talking about?"

"Huh?"

"What?"

Hyuk Mujin looked at Gung Gibang and me, his face pale.

"I've been about to shit myself this whole time, and you two keep saying the weirdest things. Seriously."

"…!"

"…!"

Touching, my ass.

When he said something bad was going to happen, he'd meant *that*.

As Gung Gibang and I stared at him, speechless, Hyuk Mujin broke into a cold sweat and hurried ahead.

"Where are we meeting? Hurry! It's coming out!"

Look at that determination. I'd never seen him look so desperate, even in a fight.

Gung Gibang pointed at a building on reflex.

"O-over there."

"That one? The three-story inn?"

"Uh? Yeah."

"Then I'm going ahead. Pooooop!"

Was that last cry sheer determination to hold it in? Or a booster powered by the last of his sphincter's strength?

Hyuk Mujin staggered as he wove through the crowd at incredible speed. Gung Gibang muttered, “Drunken Eight-Immortals Step[2491]…?”

“…Please don’t talk bullshit. He just needs to shit.”

God. Buddha. Why am I surrounded by nothing but idiots?

Lamenting my fate, I looked toward the three-story inn Hyuk Mujin was heading for.

It wasn’t far away. Yet the part of my chest that had settled down during the journey suddenly began to churn.

“…A month? No, has it been two?”

Gung Gibang narrowed his eyes at my unguarded mutter.

“Oh-ho.”

“What, you bastard?”

“Is it what I think it is?”

“You can think?”

“I’m right, aren’t I?”

“Want to get hit?”

“Come to think of it, the atmosphere back then was a little strange.”

“Want me to pick out your grave?”

“That clever dodge tells me I’m right.”

“Want me to hit you so fast you can’t dodge, clever or not?”

“Pfft. That bastard Hyuk should’ve seen this.”

“…No, it’s not— Ah, forget it.”

Normally, Gung Gibang would have changed the subject by now, if only to avoid getting hit. Today was different.

His laughter sounded like air leaking out as he kept glancing at me. My fist clenched, but strangely enough, I didn’t feel like hitting him.

“Pfft, pfft, pfft.”

“…”

Bam!

Watching him laugh brought the urge right back.

He couldn’t even scream. I grabbed him by the back of the neck and hauled him up as he clutched his solar plexus.

“So. That’s the place, right? The three-story inn.”

“Urgh. Y-yes.”

“I’m going for the food. Because I’m hungry.”

“I-I know.”

[2491] The Eight Immortals are figures in Chinese Daoist folklore. The name evokes drunken-style martial arts, whose movements can appear unsteady.

"I heard that Kunlun Cloud Dragon guy or whatever is there, too. I'm going to see him because it's been a while. And while I'm there, I'll build a little rapport with that Hwangbo fellow or whatever his name is."

"…I'll remember that."

"See that you do. Unless you want the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes to become the Nine Dragons and Phoenixes."

That seemed to drive the lesson home. Once I let him go, Gung Gibang rubbed the spot I'd hit.

"Vicious bastard."

"What was that?"

"N-nothing."

As if that would fool me. Gung Gibang hastily changed the subject.

"Anyway, I'm looking forward to it. When they hear you've come, they'll welcome you with open arms."

"I don't care whether they do or not."

I wasn't particularly interested in the Kunlun Cloud Dragon or that Lesser Family Head of the Hwangbo Family.

There was, though, one person I hoped would be genuinely glad to see me.

But Gung Gibang misunderstood my answer and hurriedly continued,

"No! Hwangbo Ak is a bit of a pain, but once he hears you came all this way, he'll come running out barefoot and—"

He never finished.

Boom!

A thunderous crash swallowed his voice and every sound on the bustling street.

A silence too brief to call an instant fell, then broke.

"Aaah!"

"Eeeeeek!"

"Gowolru! Gowolru is…!"

People screamed and scattered in every direction like a swarm of locusts.

I stood where I was and stared.

Gowolru.

I could see it clearly. A section of the three-story inn where we were supposed to meet had been blown wide open.

Someone came hurtling out through a shower of debris and a cloud of dust.

Whoosh! Crash!

A street stall not far away shattered, and a deep gouge opened in the ground.

A man managed to right himself and get to his feet.

Thud, thud, thud.

Who's that?

His martial uniform was torn to shreds, and his leather shoes had come off. His handsome face was filled with fury and dismay.

"How dare you… You bastard! I'll tear you apart…!"

Just then, Gung Gibang gaped at the man, who was speaking through clenched teeth.

"H-Hwangbo Ak!"

"…?"

"What are you doing out here?"

What? That's Hwangbo Ak?

Hwangbo Ak faltered at the sound of his name. I looked him up and down.

"He did come running out barefoot."

Was this a surprise for me? Some impromptu welcome from the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes?

Judging by the way Hwangbo Ak's face twisted, probably not.

"What did you just say?"

"Oh. Sorry. I didn't mean it that way."

"You damned bastard…"

"You look busy. Let's talk later. Ah, here it comes."

"What?"

His confusion lasted only a moment. Hwangbo Ak seemed to have forgotten something, but urgency and horror rose across his face.

Whoooosh—boom!

Something enormous shot through the air and slammed into Hwangbo Ak.

I could tell how fast it was moving, and how much force it carried, just from the sound. He would have been hard-pressed to deal with it while fully alert. Distracted as he was, the result was inevitable.

"Guhk!"

Hwangbo Ak went flying, spraying blood. A massive shadow moved to pursue him.

What should I do? I didn't have to think long.

Never a quiet day around here.

I stepped forward with a soft sigh.

An enormous man blocked out the sun, casting a vast shadow over me. He looked down at me with eyes as big as bowls.

"You. Move."

I answered calmly.

"Me. Don't want to."

Chapter 531

"You. Move."

"No. I don't want to."

"…Huh?"

He clearly hadn't expected that answer.

The giant's eyes, each as large as a child's fist, rolled around as he stammered.

"Y-You don't want to?"

"Yeah. I don't want to. I'm not moving."

"That's s-strange. Everyone moved until now."

What kind of character was this?

Did he forget to put any points into intelligence, too?

He was so huge I wondered if he had a Troll among his ancestors, but he talked and acted like a kindergartner.

I scratched my chin as I watched him fidget.

There's always a new kind of weirdo.

I thought I'd grown used to strange people after meeting so many in Murim, but I'd never met anyone quite like him. Still, settling this commotion came before satisfying my curiosity.

"Come on. Back away slowly."

"Back away?"

"Yeah."

I wasn't trying to play the hero. It wasn't as though I had some great sense of duty, either.

But we were in the middle of a main street in Henan. If the fight continued, civilians could get caught in it.

"I don't know what happened, but let's stop here. All right?"

I kept my voice gentle and glanced at Gung Gibang.

Quick to catch on, Gung Gibang understood what I meant and began evacuating the civilians who had been unable to escape and were still sitting on the ground.

The giant watched them go, his large eyes darting from side to side.

"That guy. Insulted me."

A finger as thick as a stick pointed toward Hwangbo Ak, who was bent over and coughing weakly.

"He insulted you?"

"Rootless practitioner of demonic, heterodox arts. Pig as stupid as they come. What are you going to do if you glare at me?"

"Ah."

“My lord said to think three times before fighting. So I thought three times and fought. He drew his sword first, too.”

That gave me a fair idea of what had happened. His words were short and disjointed, but they were enough.

Hwangbo Ak was the Lesser Family Head of the Hwangbo Family, which held sway over Shandong. It wasn’t hard to imagine a Murim golden spoon[2492] talented enough to join the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes picking a fight with a martial artist he considered demonic and heterodox. Gung Gibang had called Hwangbo Ak a pain in the ass before, too.

So this guy’s from the unorthodox faction.

No wonder the aura coming off him had felt unusual.

Aside from some Third Rate dark-path figures, I had never met a proper martial artist who practiced demonic, heterodox arts. I had to forcibly suppress the curiosity that suddenly rose inside me.

A thought had just crossed my mind.

“Did you lay a hand on anyone else?”

“Someone else?”

“Yeah. There must have been… other people with him.”

My heart gave a small thump. Ju Hwaran’s three-syllable name hovered on the tip of my tongue, but I couldn’t bring myself to say it.

The giant tilted his head and blinked.

“There were. Two men. One was strong, and one was weak. And…”

“And?”

“A pretty woman. A very pretty woman.”

“Damn. You’ve got a good eye.”

“Huh?”

“Nothing. Did you fight them, too?”

“No. I only hit that guy. The pretty woman. She was as kind as she was beautiful.”

She was safe.

I breathed a silent sigh of relief and patted the giant on the shoulder.

“Yeah, yeah. Good job. What a good little boy.”

“Good job? I’m good?”

“Of course you are. So let’s make up now. Got it?”

“Hmm. Hmmmm.”

I’d almost won him over.

[2492] “Golden spoon” translates *geumsujeo*, a Korean expression for someone born into wealth or privilege.

When I heard he was from the unorthodox faction, I'd wondered if I should just knock him down. Apparently, coaxing him like a kindergartner in the Sunshine Class would do.

Just as his eyes began rolling with the effort of thinking it over, an angry shout rang out behind me.

"What do you think you're doing?"

I turned. Hwangbo Ak had straightened up and was glaring at us, his eyes blazing.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon! Are my ears deceiving me? You're taking the side of a demonic, heterodox practitioner!"

We'd never met, but apparently he knew me. Neither of us had time for introductions anyway, so that was convenient.

I calmly gestured toward Hwangbo Ak.

"You're up. Come over here and make up with him."

"M-Make up?"

"From what I've heard, he had his reasons. Let's not cause any more trouble. Be a man, shake hands, and call it done. No hard feelings."

Hwangbo Ak's eyes went wide, like someone who'd picked Yasuo[2493] and immediately been hit with an insult about his family.

"How can you do this?"

"I can do it just fine. Come over while I'm asking nicely."

"A fellow orthodox martial artist has been harmed by a practitioner of demonic, heterodox arts. How can you take the side of that vile unorthodox whelp?"

"What does it matter whether he's unorthodox or orthodox? We're all one family in the Murim Alliance. Haven't you heard the song? We are all friends. That's right, that's right."

"What song are you talking about? And one family? Have you forgotten what those demonic, heterodox bastards did during the Great Faction War?"

"Forgot? I wasn't even there. Were you in the Great Faction War? You look younger than I thought."

"Enough nonsense. Move! This Young Master will make that bastard kneel and apologize!"

Whoosh.

A warm breeze suddenly blew over my head. It was the breath of the giant, who stood a head—no, two heads—taller than me.

"Kneel? You. Me?"

Hwangbo Ak flinched for a moment, then gritted his teeth.

"Fine. You pushed me back earlier with a despicable surprise attack, but I'll make you regret provoking this Young Master even after death!"

[2493] Yasuo is a playable character in the video game *League of Legends*.

"This won't do. You. I kill."

The giant's eyes went cold.

Fwoosh—whoosh!

A piercing sound tore into my ears.

Hwangbo Ak shot forward like a ray of light, his body twisting fiercely. His leg whipped out, sheathed in visible internal energy.

A kicking technique?

For generations, the Hwangbo Family had produced masters of punches and kicks. This had to be one of the secret martial arts that had made them the rulers of Shandong.

But…

"You! I kill!"

He'd picked the wrong opponent.

The giant's martial prowess was certainly no less than Hwangbo Ak's. He might even have been a move or two ahead.

A massive two-section staff, well suited to his frame, had appeared in his hands.

Whoosh!

Fast and powerful.

The staff swept forward as if crushing the space in its path. I could feel the giant's tremendous strength and speed behind it.

I watched until the last possible moment, then quietly extended both arms.

Boom!

A deafening crash sent a wave of qi surging outward. Materials, dust, and dirt scattered across the street were driven beyond a three-zhang[2494] radius. People gasped.

In the middle of it all, two pairs of eyes trembled.

How?

The question was plain in the giant's eyes and Hwangbo Ak's. They stared in shock at the staff and leg caught in my hands.

One movement had stopped both attacks—and the fight.

"Th-This…"

"Strong! You, strong!"

I met their wavering gazes and spoke slowly.

"Now, let's make up."

Ah. I'd forgotten to add something.

"Unless you want me to beat you to death."

[2494] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese unit of length, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three zhang is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

"…!"

"…!"

Kind words could get you far. Kind words and a fist could get you farther.

The giant stared at me blankly for a moment before stammering, "I-I will make up. I'm good."

"Yeah, you're good. Now, who wants to be a bad little boy?"

My gaze turned to Hwangbo Ak. He pressed his lips together.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, are you really planning to—"

"Oh! More information just came in! Every bad little boy I've met so far got beaten nearly to death by me and turned good!"

"…Come to think of it, I suppose I was at fault too."

"Good. Then we're settled."

Only then did I release the two-section staff and the ankle I'd been gripping.

The giant kept stealing bewildered glances at me. Hwangbo Ak trembled with humiliation, but he didn't dare resume the fight. He only glared at me with anger and fear in his eyes, his lips moving soundlessly.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. Can you still call yourself orthodox after this?"

"Wow. That's exactly what I was about to ask you."

"I see. You must be acting this way because you don't know who this Young Master is…"

"Hwangbo Ak. Twenty-nine years old. Lesser Family Head of the Hwangbo Family. Sobriquet: Shandong Fist Dragon."

"…!"

"Oh, and you recently had a wet dream."

"I did not!"

"Then forget I said it."

Hwangbo Ak's clenched fist trembled.

"You know who I am, and you still humiliate me like this?"

"A fucking idiot has no gender, age, or orthodox or unorthodox faction. That's my view, and you're proving it right."

If I'd left him to fight, the giant would have beaten the soul out of him. I'd stepped in before things got worse, and now I had to listen to this nonsense.

So why am I not angry?

After a moment, I realized why.

He was an even bigger idiot than I'd expected. And he was too insignificant to get worked up over.

An insect.

That was all Hwangbo Ak was to me. An ant that would die if I flicked it with a finger. A mosquito that a careless wave of my hand would leave half-dead.

I'd spent so long among giants that I'd become one myself. I felt like Gulliver arriving in Lilliput.

Hwangbo Ak was no exception. Even his status as the Hwangbo Family's Lesser Family Head and one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes meant little to me.

Just a Lilliputian who's a little bigger than the others.

That was how Gulliver—how I—saw him. Maybe some of it showed in my eyes.

Hwangbo Ak's face darkened with rage.

"Y-You…"

"Want some advice?"

"What?"

"Know where you stand before you pick a fight."

"You bastard!"

He shouted, but I didn't blink. He needed to carve my next words into his bones.

"The Roaring Fury Swordsman. The Taeeul Merciless Sword. You've heard those names plenty, haven't you? Though maybe not so much lately. They're both busy recovering."

"…!"

"If you don't want the Shandong Fist Dragon added to that list, don't try anything funny. That's your first and last warning."

Whoosh.

I focused my aura on him alone. Hwangbo Ak sucked in a breath.

He must have heard what had happened to the Zhongnan Sect Leader's two Senior Brothers. And now he'd been reminded that Murim ran on two things: a just cause and the law of strength.

Tap.

I patted his trembling shoulder and smiled.

"You look like you're having a hard time. I'll explain things to the others, so go home."

"B-But…"

"Go."

All Hwangbo Ak could do was grit his teeth and leave.

When his back, looking unusually small, had receded into the distance, a voice reached my ears.

"Sir Jin!"

I hadn't heard it in a long time, which made it all the more welcome.

Chapter 532

The young man thought long and hard.

Where did it all go wrong?

Was it when he'd forced down the dumplings someone had bought? Or when he'd ignored the dull ache in his stomach and dozed off while standing guard?

He couldn't say where or how things had gone wrong. But one thing was certain.

Boom!

The thunderous roar that had suddenly erupted the moment he entered the privy had ended everything for him.

"Ahhh, so warm…"

His Captain had once told him that giving up made things easier.

He had been right. The pleasure was heavenly, and warmth like a mother's embrace spread through the young man's lower body.

So why were tears running down his cheeks?

Why else? Fuck.

He'd shit himself. He'd actually shit himself.

In the privy of a large inn on a crowded main street.

It was an expensive inn that only people with money to spare could afford to enter. The partitions between the privies offered a little comfort, but they didn't change the fact that he could never leave like this.

If anyone finds out what happened, I'm finished.

His spine prickled and his insides twisted at the thought.

Strip a martial artist of his pride and martial arts, and all that remained was skin.

He'd sooner fight a cruel fiend in a life-and-death duel than be discovered like this and have the story spread.

What do I do?

The greatest dilemma of his life.

His pants and underwear had to go. The leather shoes he'd recently splurged on were already beyond saving.

What if he took everything off, pulled his shirt over his face, and ran across the main street as fast as he could?

I'd die.

In Murim, it was practically legal to beat a man to death for sprinting down the main street with everything dangling.

Every passing martial artist would rush out and start swinging their weapons. He might even receive an attack worse than anything a Dark Heaven fiend could unleash.

Then I'll have to ask someone for help. An inn attendant, maybe.

That was better. If he called an attendant over and slipped him a few silver nyang,[2495] the man would bring him a cloth to wipe himself down and some clothes.

If the attendant knew who he was, it might cost extra, but that was still cheaper than a funeral.

What about the others…? No. I can't let Captain or Gung Gibang see me like this!

Hyuk Mujin made a solemn vow.

Unfortunately, his traveling companions were more persistent than venomous snakes. If they got hold of a weakness like this, they'd tease him for ten years at least. Maybe twenty or thirty.

No, they would probably keep going until the very moment Hyuk Mujin was on his deathbed.

"Mujin…"

"Oh, you Hyuk bastard!"

"Heh heh. You arrived right on time, Captain. And Great Hero Gung."

"Sob. Of course I had to arrive on time! You were late that day and shit your pants, but I'm not going to be late!"

"Rest easy, Hyuk. You can stink up the place behind the folding screen all you want now."

"…Please stop."

A miserable end, even to imagine.

For a moment, he considered asking an attendant to fetch Cheongpung from their lodgings. But that would be digging his own grave.

"Wow! This is the first time I've seen someone who shit his pants! At first, I thought you were a snake! You're a Thousand-Year Dung-Horned Snake that looks just like Mimi!"

"Wait. Cheongpung! Wait!"

"Stay here. I'll go get the others! Excuse me! Daoist from Wudang! Someone I know shit his pants over here…"

"You fucking bastard!"

He'd be a hundred times better off walking around with a sign around his neck that read *I Shit My Pants*.

Hyuk Mujin was trembling from the chills brought on by the horrifying images filling his mind when it happened.

Rattle.

The door opened, and he sensed someone's presence.

[2495] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. It has no fixed modern won exchange rate.

Hyuk Mujin's eyes flew open, and he cleared his throat.

"Ahem. Ahem."

When no one answered, he coughed louder.

"Ahem! Ahem! Is anyone there? Cough, cough!"

"Hm?"

At last, a response. Hyuk Mujin swallowed and forced his voice into a dignified tone.

"Are you an inn attendant?"

Someone outside answered. The young man's voice was soft, but he spoke with the easy familiarity of someone addressing an inferior.

"You seem to be looking for an attendant, but unfortunately, I don't have time to worry about that. You heard it yourself, so you know there's quite a commotion going on."

How could Hyuk Mujin not have heard? That damned crash was the reason he was in this mess. The building hadn't collapsed, but everyone seemed busy dealing with the damage.

At least someone's still coming to the privy in the middle of all this.

Just as the thought crossed his mind, the man said, "Well, I'll leave you to it."

His presence began to recede.

Hyuk Mujin's heart dropped.

"W-Wait! Just a moment!"

"Hm?"

"Sorry, but could you help me? I really need help."

"Well, I'm busy myself."

"A small problem has come up."

"If it's small, you can take care of it yourself."

"Wait! Hyung![2496] Father! Benefactor!"

After a short silence, the voice returned.

"Did you shit yourself?"

Did you shit yourself? Did you shit yourself? Did you shit yourself?

The question echoed in Hyuk Mujin's ears. He answered through tears.

"Sniff. I did."

"The big one or the small one?"

"…"

"Good grief. Both?"

"Urgh. Sob…"

[2496] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or, familiarly, an older man.

The man outside muttered, “I suppose taking care of the big one takes care of the small one, too.”

“Please. Please help me.”

“If I see an attendant on my way, I’ll tell him.”

“C-Couldn’t you bring me something now? It might be dry by the time an attendant gets here!”

“…That’s disgusting. I have someone to meet, so I’ll be going.”

“W-Wait!”

Desperate, Hyuk Mujin squeezed his eyes shut.

“I-I’m Hyuk Mujin! You seem to be a martial artist too, Brother. Help me this once and keep quiet about it, and I’ll never forget the favor!”

“Hyuk Mujin? The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon’s little toe?”

“…That’s me. But I’m his right arm, not his little toe.”

Hyuk Mujin’s vision went dark. He’d guessed the man was a martial artist, but he hadn’t expected him to recognize the name so quickly.

At least he’d stopped the man from leaving.

“Coincidence or fate? I’m not sure. Interesting.”

“…?”

Flap.

Just as Hyuk Mujin was wondering what he meant, a silk outer robe fluttered down over his head, accompanied by a low chuckle whose meaning he could not understand.

Hyuk Mujin caught the robe and stammered his thanks.

“T-Thank you.”

“Clean yourself up and come out. I’ll give you a chance to repay the favor.”

“Um. Do you happen to know our Captain…?”

“We’ve never met. But I doubt the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon will treat me poorly.”

The soft voice continued.

“Not when I’m the benefactor who helped his little toe—or rather, his right arm.”

“…!”

Hyuk Mujin didn’t know who the man was, but he knew he’d gotten himself into something serious.

It was too late for regrets. His face stiff, he asked, “Is that why you gave me the robe?”

“Why? Have you changed your mind? Then I’ll throw the robe back—”

“If we’re doing this, could you get me some clothes to wear too? Wiping myself down won’t be enough.”

"…"

Gowolru.

That was the name of the luxurious three-story inn.

An inn that large must have dealt with trouble often. The moment we stepped inside, the owner came toward us as if he'd been waiting, with a dozen or so hired martial artists in tow.

His face was grim.

"I don't know who you are, but even young heroes of the martial world must pay for the damage they cause—"

I cut him off.

"First, you have my sympathies. How much will the repairs cost?"

"What?"

"The repairs."

"…About two hundred silver nyang.[2497]"

"Then let's make it three hundred,[2498] including compensation for everything else."

"What?"

At most, part of the third-floor railing and wall had collapsed.

The owner had gone out on a limb and asked for two hundred nyang,[2499] only for me to counter with three hundred. From his perspective, he probably had no idea what kind of person I was.

But I had no qualms about offering an enormous sum.

The reason was simple.

It wasn't my money.

"Put it on the Hwangbo Family's tab. If that Lesser Family Head bastard gives you trouble when you go to collect, tell him Jin Taekyung sent you."

"How am I supposed to say— Wait. Jin Taekyung?"

The owner and the hired blades, who had been studying me suspiciously, opened their eyes wide.

"J-Jin Taekyung? The Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon! It's the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!"

"I have descended."

[2497] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. It has no fixed modern won exchange rate.

[2498] A nyang is a traditional unit of currency; silver nyang refers to silver-denominated money. It has no fixed modern won exchange rate.

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Running an inn this size on a main street in Henan took ability. Gowolru's owner was certainly quick on the uptake.

"Great Hero Jin Taekyung, it's the honor of a lifetime to have you here!"

"Call it an honor for your whole family. Anyway, my throat's been feeling a little dry…"

"I'll bring out a feast that breaks the table legs! What are you all standing around for?"

Nothing calmed a man down like financial therapy.

The owner's eyes had brightened as if he'd forgotten all about his anger. He hurried off with the hired blades, and a soft laugh came from beside me.

The sound alone made my ears itch. I turned toward it.

"What?"

Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran looked at me with eyes like forget-me-nots.

"Nothing. I was just thinking about last time."

"Last time? Ah."

"You haven't forgotten, have you?"

"Of course not."

The dispute between the Yongbong Escort Bureau and the Zhongnan Sect.

I'd stumbled into it on my way to Sichuan to seek treatment for Jeok Cheongang. After putting a stop to the Taeeul Merciless Sword's attempt to settle things by force, I'd even taken part in the negotiations.

I uprooted two or three of Zhongnan Sect's foundation pillars back then.

Hwaran was clearly remembering it too. Her eyes shone softly as she looked at me.

"It hasn't been that long, but it feels like ages."

"It does. Strange, isn't it?"

The strange part was how hard I was finding it to look the person I was talking to in the eye.

"Why do you keep looking away?"

"I'm cross-eyed. I'm looking straight at you."

"Pfft."

"W-Why are you laughing?"

Had I said something wrong?

Hwaran smiled at my confusion.

"You really haven't changed, Great Hero Jin. Not a bit."

"You haven't changed either, Young Lady Ju…"

Something else nearly slipped out, but I managed to hold it back.

The several pairs of narrowed eyes watching us from beside me helped.

I pretended to cough and sent a Sound Transmission.

—Gib, what are you staring at? Want a hole punched through your solar plexus?

—Ahem. Ahem.

One down.

Three more to go.

I fixed my gaze on the one who looked least useful.

—Hey.

Hak Woo, the Kunlun Cloud Dragon, was the Kunlun Sect's finest young prodigy. I'd stepped on the top of his head and sent him tumbling down during the Star-Array Grand Banquet preliminaries.

For some reason, he'd since developed a round bald patch. He flinched when I looked at him and sent a Sound Transmission back.

—W-What is it, Fellow Daoist Jin?

—Nothing much. I thought you might have something to do.

—Hm?

—Be honest. You're busy right now, aren't you?

—Infinite Life Buddha.[2500] I'm not busy.

—I don't think so. I think you've just remembered something urgent and need to leave right away.

—I have already received permission from my sect regarding today's appointment. There's no urgent matter that I need to attend to—

—Hey, Hak.

—Infinite Life Buddha?[2501]

—Go. Unless you want me to pluck out every last hair on your head.

—…!

To a balding man, every hair was as precious as his life. Hak Woo finally got the message. Looking ready to cry, he turned to Hwaran.

"Um. Young Lady Ju."

"Yes? What is it?"

"This humble Daoist has remembered an urgent matter and must leave. I'm terribly sorry, Young Lady Ju."

"It's all right. Please, go ahead."

"But it's still rude of me to—"

"I can't walk you out very far. Take care."

"Wait. Could you at least let me finish…"

"I'll see you next time!"

Now that I thought about it, Hwaran seemed a little impatient.

[2500] "Infinite Life Buddha" is an invocation referring to Amitabha, the Buddha of Infinite Life.

[2501] "Infinite Life Buddha" is an invocation referring to Amitabha, the Buddha of Infinite Life.

Kunlun Cloud Dragon Hak Woo looked back and forth between Ju Hwaran and me with eyes on the verge of tears before disappearing, and my gaze naturally shifted to the two people I had yet to deal with.

"I'll tell you now: I'm not leaving. I'm the Young Bureau Head's personal escort."

Song Ilseom, an escort sitting crookedly with a single sword tucked against his chest, spoke flatly.

"I didn't ask you to. Wasn't planning to, either."

"Hm. I'll take your word for it."

Song Ilseom was publicly known as Hwaran's escort, but he had another identity known to only a handful of people.

He was the last descendant of the Guangdong Chen Family, an iron-blooded martial family wiped out by the Demonic Cult during the Great Faction War. He was also an undefeated wandering martial artist once known as the Soul-Chasing Guest.

This guy hasn't changed, either.

I'd been famous when we first met, but it was nothing compared to now. Song Ilseom was still as calm and prickly as he'd been back then.

Maybe that was why I liked him even more.

But the last one…

"Hungry. Food. Taking too long."

"…"

What was with that shameless attitude?

Why had this giant, whose identity I didn't know, followed us here? I hadn't stopped him because I wanted to find out who he was.

Qi Sense could tell me little more than his Level and name. If I wanted to know his sect and who he was connected to, I'd have to talk to him.

"You must be pretty hungry."

"Yes. I, very hungry."

The giant continued with a serious expression.

"Today, only ate six meals. Feel like dying."

"…"

Six meals? Seriously?

I didn't know which sect he belonged to, but I'd bet Hyuk Mujin's wrist that feeding this guy had already cost them a few foundation pillars.

Wait. Hyuk Mujin?

Come to think of it, he'd gone off to take a shit. Why wasn't he back yet?

I'd just noticed his absence and was looking around when I heard him.

"C-Captain!"

For some reason, he sounded terribly anxious.

But I wasn’t looking at Hyuk Mujin, who had finally reappeared. I was looking at the unfamiliar man behind him.

He was smiling at me. Our eyes met, and I muttered, “Now who might that be…?”

Chapter 533

The third floor, where the commotion had broken out earlier, had long since emptied.

Not many people had the nerve to sit drinking as if nothing had happened after a fight between martial artists had brought down the railings and even parts of the walls.

Besides, martial artists wealthy and important enough to frequent Gowolru were more likely to drink at a winehouse than an ordinary inn.

So it wasn't hard to guess what the uninvited guest, still smiling amid the wreckage, was.

A martial artist.

That much was obvious.

The man looked thirty at most. He had an open, handsome face, and a dark saber scabbard hung at his waist.

And then there was…

His aura.

I let out a silent whistle. The power and aura I sensed from him surpassed those of every member of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes I'd met so far.

Even Jin Mukyung before he entered seclusion.

Could it be?

A name I knew but had yet to put a face to flashed through my mind.

Murong Yeonghwi, the One-Ride Heavenly Dragon. Eldest son of the Murong Family, and foremost among the ten dragons and phoenixes hailed as Murim's greatest young prodigies.

Should I use Qi Sense to check his name?

While I was considering it, Hyuk Mujin approached looking like he desperately needed to shit.

"Um, he's an acquaintance of mine. He said he really wanted to meet you, Captain…"

I kept my eyes on the man.

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"I'm genuinely curious. You didn't expect me to believe that, did you?"

"Ghk."

"Tell me the truth. Now."

"…I shit my pants, and he helped me."

"I figured it was something like that. We'll talk later. Step aside."

As Hyuk Mujin backed away with an expression like he wanted to kill himself, the smile at the corners of the man's mouth deepened.

"Well, now. You're quicker on the uptake than I expected."

"Not really. It'd be stranger if a textile-shop owner's son had a friend like you."

"Hm. I didn't know that. Though, to be honest, I didn't have particularly high expectations."

"You're taking your time introducing yourself. Who are you?"

"A traveler passing through."

"And you're talking pretty casually for someone we've just met."

"If it bothers you, speak casually yourself. Make yourself comfortable."

He was an odd one. He felt different from the others I'd met. I folded my arms loosely.

"Sure. Let's do that."

He laughed aloud.

"I'd only heard rumors about the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. You're more entertaining than they led me to believe."

"It's not exactly a fun situation from where I'm standing. Anyway, are you still planning to introduce yourself as a passing traveler?"

"You don't know me, then. A few people here seem to."

His gaze shifted to Ju Hwaran, Gung Gibang, and Song Ilseom.

The faint smile Hwaran had worn only moments ago was gone. Her expression hardened.

"It's been a while, Young Sect Leader."

Young Sect Leader?

The question slipped out before I could stop it.

"Young Lady Ju. You know him?"

"We met once. In Gansu."

"Gansu…"

Along with Qinghai and Sichuan, it was one of the regions hit hardest during the Great Faction War. It was also home to the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

I studied the man.

"You don't look like a Kongtong Daoist to me. Tell me now if I've got that wrong."

"No, you've got it right. Quite the opposite, in fact."

He shrugged.

"If Kongtong found out it had been associated with a demonic, heterodox practitioner like me, it would be displeased. Of course, I feel the same way."

"A demonic, heterodox practitioner?"

"Ever heard of the Black Dragon Demon Gate?"

Black Dragon Demon Gate. It didn't take long to place the name.

"I have."

I'd heard of the unorthodox sect that held sway over Gansu. Kongtong might be among the weakest of the Nine Sects and One Gang, but I'd still been surprised to learn that an unorthodox sect shunned by the public could wield that much power there.

Now I get why this guy isn't one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

In that respect, he was much like Song Ilseom.

People could talk all they wanted about all Murim standing together as fellow martial artists. In the end, they still had their own little club.

People—orthodox martial artists, that is—didn't want wandering martial artists who sold their swords for money or demonic, heterodox practitioners they saw as criminals-in-waiting among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

"So what brings the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate here?"

The man's brow furrowed.

"That's all?"

"What else do you want?"

"Well…"

"Oh, if you've got more to say, give me your sobriquet. I might forget it, but I ought to hear it first."

"…Black Dragon Saber. Sama Pyo."

"I didn't ask for your name. But all right, now I know."

"…"

"Cool name, though. Any relation to Sima Yi?[2502]"

"What?"

"What do you mean, what? Sima Yi. The one from *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*."

Sama Pyo looked taken aback.

"We share a surname. That's all."

"Really? What a shame. If you were sworn enemies of the Zhuge Clan, I was going to introduce you to someone I know."

"…That doesn't mean I'm on good terms with the Zhuge Clan."

"Yeah, fair enough. So why are you here?"

Sama Pyo studied me with a strange gaze before speaking.

"I came for my subordinate."

[2502] "Sama" and "Sima" are Korean and Mandarin readings of the same surname, □□. In *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, Sima Yi is a rival of Zhuge Liang.

"Your subordinate?"

"Yes. That bear of a man sitting over there."

No one at the table had to ask who he meant. Every gaze, mine included, turned toward the giant.

Despite standing eight cheok[2503] tall, he was hunched in on himself, watching Sama Pyo nervously.

"Taishan.[2504] Get up."

He's with the Black Dragon Demon Gate, too?

Whoever had named him had certainly picked the right name.

At Sama Pyo's call, the mountain of a man answered in his halting voice.

"Lord. I am not Taishan. You have wrong person."

"…"

He really needs to put some points into Intelligence.

Sama Pyo clicked his tongue.

"You troublemaker. Every time I leave you alone, you cause a scene. Enough. Get up."

"Cannot. Food not here yet."

"What a bear of a man. You've eaten that much and you're still not full?"

"Today. Only six meals. Barely ate."

"What? Six meals?"

Sama Pyo's face went rigid.

"Only six? Have you suffered an Internal Injury?"

"…"

"…"

Fuck. I don't even know what to say.

While the rest of us sat speechless, Sama Pyo gave it some thought and nodded.

"All right. We'll eat before we go."

"Food! Good! Taishan eat all food here!"

I spoke from the heart.

"Could you please take that guy—Taishan or the whole beautiful landscape, whatever his name is—and get the hell out?"

Where do these lunatics get off trying to join our table?

Sama Pyo frowned.

"That's stingy."

"Yes! Stingy! But Lord, what is stingy?"

[2503] A cheok is a Korean unit of length, about 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Eight cheok is about 2.42 m (7 ft 11 in).

[2504] Taishan (□□) means "great mountain," fitting the man's enormous build. Taekyung's later "Taishan or the whole beautiful landscape" rhymes the Korean reading *Taesan* with *geumsu gangsan*, "land of embroidered rivers and mountains," a poetic name for Korea.

"Taishan, it's short for 'hey, you fucking bastards.'"

Having kindly explained it to a child from the Sunshine Class,[2505] I pointed at the stairs.

"So please leave now, you fucking bastards."

"…!"

A heavy tension settled over the room.

Hwaran exhaled and reached for the flexible sword at her waist. Song Ilseom straightened from his relaxed posture.

Their sudden wariness had one target.

Sama Pyo.

But he didn't move. His eyes widened slightly, and he merely stared at me with an unreadable look.

Then his tightly closed lips parted, and a gentle voice flowed out.

"How refreshing. I've never had an experience like this in Gansu—or in my entire life."

"The first time is the hardest. It gets easier from the second time onward. I'll give you plenty more of it from now on, so don't worry."

"Plenty more in the future, too?"

"I get the feeling we'll be seeing each other often. Could be wrong."

"You're certainly different. Very different. Don't you agree?"

The question wasn't for me.

Taishan, whose huge eyes had been darting around, nodded.

"Lord. Yes. That man. Different."

"Yes, I believe he is."

A smile I couldn't read appeared on Sama Pyo's face, then vanished.

The next moment, Sama Pyo reached up and grabbed Taishan by the nape of his neck, far above his own head, then hauled him upright.

"Hard to linger where we aren't welcome. Come on, you fool."

"Taishan disappointed. But Taishan follows Lord. Obeys well."

"Then we'll be going. See you again, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. And you too, Young Lady Ju."

With that, they went downstairs. A little later, I heard the inn's door close, and Hwaran's stiff expression eased.

"Whew."

She let out a quiet sigh. Song Ilseom leaned back in his chair.

[2505] Sunshine Class is the sort of name given to a kindergarten class; the comparison casts Taishan as a young child.

"He's stronger than before. No—more dangerous might be the better way to put it."

That only deepened the question I'd been turning over.

From their reactions, they'd clearly met before. More than that, something had happened between them.

What was it?

Perhaps someone noticed my expression, because a foot tapped mine beneath the table.

Tap. Tap.

I didn't need to look. It was Gung Gibang. He moved his chapped lips.

—Don't say anything. And don't ask.

—Why?

—Just don't, you fucking bastard.

What the hell is his problem? What's this about?

But that was how people worked. Even if I wasn't going to ask Hwaran herself, I wanted to hear it from someone who knew.

—What happened?

—Not telling.

—Why?

—You're better off not knowing.

At that moment, Ju Hwaran, who was sitting right beside Gung Gibang and directly across from me, handed me a plate with a smile.

"Try this, Great Hero Jin."

"Ah, yes."

I ought to have smiled back. For some reason, I couldn't.

I stuffed the food she'd given me into my mouth and kept sending Sound Transmissions.

—Tell me.

—No.

—I said tell me.

—And I said no.

This fucking guy.

He could at least have pretended he knew nothing. Instead, he'd let on that there was a story, then dug in his heels. I was getting pissed off.

I was about to send another Sound Transmission when Hwaran spoke.

"Oh, Great Hero Jin. There's something I forgot to tell you."

"Tell me while I'm still asking nicely, okay?"

I nearly made a huge mistake.

I looked up, my mouth full of food, and Hwaran continued.
“That man. The Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.”
“Sama Pyo?”
“Mm. Yes.”
“Uh… Did something happen?”
“You could say it did. Or you could say it didn’t.”
Hwaran looked straight at me and said one sentence.
No. It was a bomb.
“He used to be my fiancé.”
“Pffft!”
“Aaaaaah!”
“Uaaaaah!”

Chapter 534

Jingle. Clack.

The inn's door closed on the final ring of its bell. With it went the stares that had stabbed at the back of Sama Pyo's head all the way down the stairs.

But Sama Pyo already knew this wasn't the end. It was another beginning.

"Those two who just came out of Gowolru…"

"That's them, right?"

"I'm certain. That's the Black Dragon Saber, Sama Pyo—the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate. And the huge fellow beside him is the monster who crushed Blood Cudgel's skull seven days and nights ago."

"I heard he got into a fight with the Hwangbo Family's Lesser Family Head earlier. Making trouble like that at a time like this… Tsk, tsk."

"Leave them be. What else would you expect from demonic, heterodox practitioners? We need even their help to drive out Dark Heaven."

"I don't like it one bit. How do we know they won't stab us in the back?"

"That's what I'm saying… Shh. The big fellow is looking this way."

Countless eyes watched them, and whispers followed. However quietly the onlookers spoke, they were close enough for Sama Pyo to hear every word if he cared to listen.

He kept walking, his expression unchanged.

Nothing unusual about it.

He knew the situation all too well. Even in Gansu, where the Black Dragon Demon Gate held immense influence, people had treated him the same way. The label *demonic, heterodox practitioner* had followed him since birth, a shackle he could never take off.

"Whoof."

A rough snort came from beside him. Sama Pyo glanced at Taishan, whose enormous eyes were darting around, and moved his lips.

—Stop.

Taishan's hand froze on its way to the two-section staff strapped across his back. Sama Pyo put more force into his Sound Transmission.

—Taishan. You little rascal.

—…Understood, Lord. Taishan will hold back.

—That's right. Good boy.

—Taishan listens well. Taishan likes Lord. Hehehe.

Taishan broke into a broad grin as though nothing had happened, and Sama Pyo let out a quiet laugh.

—Yes. I like you very much, too.

—Taishan got praised a lot today.

—Oh? Who was kind enough to praise you?

—Mm. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon praised me.

Sama Pyo slowed.

—Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung?

—Yes. Jin Taekyung. Said Taishan was a good boy.

—You seem to like him.

—Like him. Very strong. Good. Taishan praised him.

Sama Pyo gazed at Taishan's profile as the giant strode along excitedly.

Taishan had been born with outstanding martial talent and divine strength, but an accident long ago had injured his head and left him much like a child. Perhaps because he remembered the accident, he was wary of strangers and slow to trust anyone but Sama Pyo.

It's rare for him to speak so highly of someone else.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

Sama Pyo pictured the young man's carefree, sly manner—and the unfathomably powerful aura concealed beneath his calm face and voice.

There's a reason they call him a Divine Dragon.

The world was vast, and masters were plentiful. People admired the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes as Murim's finest young prodigies, but Sama Pyo had never acknowledged them.

Empty reputations bestowed inside walls they built themselves.

Anyone outside those walls was rejected. He had met plenty of orthodox martial artists who behaved shamelessly while hiding behind tiresome words like *righteousness* and *the orthodox path*.

But…

He was different. No question about it.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

Although their meeting had been brief, Sama Pyo had realized one thing for certain.

His astonishing martial power, which far surpassed that of any young prodigy, was one reason. But what made him feel even more extraordinary was his attitude—the way he differed from everyone else.

Their conversation from moments ago came back to him.

"I don't know whether you've heard of the Black Dragon Demon Gate."

"So what brings someone as important as the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate here?"

"Is that all?"

"What else do you need?"

"…!"

The question had caught Sama Pyo so completely off guard that he'd had no answer. No one had ever asked him that in all his years as the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

What else do I need? What else…

His lips moved soundlessly around the thought. Then he turned to Taishan.

—Let me ask you one thing.

—…?

—If you had to fight Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, what would you do?

In an instant, the smile vanished from Taishan's face. His expression hardened, and his Sound Transmission followed without the slightest hesitation.

—Taishan owes Lord a great debt. If Lord commands it, Taishan fights anyone.

—Didn't you say you liked Jin Taekyung?

—Like Jin Taekyung. But not as much as Lord. Taishan would give his life to obey Lord.

—I see.

Sama Pyo gave a small laugh and shook his head.

—That's enough. You're a good fellow.

—Taishan good. And good Taishan hungry.

The enormous child looked at him with a mournful face. Sama Pyo laughed aloud.

"Come on. We'll go somewhere. Tonight, I'll feed you until you're fit to burst."

"Hehehe. Lord promised. Taishan believes Lord."

"Yes, yes."

"But, Lord."

"Hm?"

"That woman earlier. Pretty. Very pretty. Who?"

Sama Pyo stopped dead. Taishan noticed and tilted his head.

"Lord?"

"No. Was she really that pretty?"

"Yes. Pretty and good."

"They say you can see ten fathoms into the water, but not one fathom into a person's heart. How could you know what was hidden inside her after seeing only her face for a moment?"

Taishan shook his head fiercely.

"No! Pretty women are good!"

"Don't shout. People are staring."

"Admit it! Taishan is right! Pretty means good!"

"Whew. You damned fool. I'm going on ahead."

"Lord! Lord!"

Sama Pyo walked away, leaving Taishan's desperate cries behind him. His face was as dry and expressionless as sand.

Ju Hwaran… I never expected to meet her here.

Whether it was coincidence or fate, Sama Pyo couldn't say.

But one thing was certain. The woman who had been his fiancée, if only for a short time—Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran—would consider everything connected to him an ill-fated relationship.

An ill-fated relationship… It wouldn't be wrong.

His gaze turned cold.

The rest of the meal went smoothly. The innkeeper treated us lavishly, everyone else kept staring, and outside the inn we exchanged farewells.

No. To be precise, it would be more accurate to say that Ju Hwaran said farewell to us.

"I should get going. I have some Escort Bureau matters to take care of."

Jab.

Gung Gibang poked me discreetly in the side. I'd been standing there in a daze, but my mouth opened on reflex.

"Oh, right. Goodbye."

"Yes. You too, Great Hero Jin."

Jab.

Damn it. Apparently that wasn't the right answer.

"Um, Young Lady Ju."

"Yes?"

"Would you like me to walk you back to your lodgings?"

"Thank you, but I'll be fine. I hear you barely have enough time to train as it is."

"Oh. Who told you? I have been a little busy lately."

Jab. Jab jab.

Thanks, you bastard.

Gung-vigation was warning me I'd veered off course again. I tightened my grip on the wheel.

"Still, some strange men might approach you. It might be better if I walked you back…"

"Ahaha. I'll be fine. I'm a martial artist, too."

"Oh, right. I didn't mean to underestimate you. It's just…"

"No, my martial arts really do fall short of yours, Great Hero Jin. Besides, Captain Song is here."

Song Ilseom spoke bluntly. "If any of them approach, I'll cut them down in one stroke. Stop worrying about nothing."

"You heard him, right?"

"…Yes. I heard him."

Jab jab. Jabjabjabjab!

You're going to put a hole in my side, you bastard.

But I couldn't think of anything else to say. Thoughts tangled in my already muddled head, then slipped away. By the time I found any words, the moment had passed.

"I'll be going, then. See you again."

Hwaran smiled and turned away. Her fine, silken hair swayed, carrying a faint fragrance through the air.

I stood watching the two of them walk away.

That was when—

"This guy really is a fucking idiot."

"Wow. You're something else, Captain."

"…"

I didn't need to turn to know who'd spoken. I looked at Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin with a mournful gaze.

"Where did I go wrong, and when?"

They answered at the same time, as if they'd been waiting.

"Since you spat food in Young Lady Ju's face."

"Wasn't Captain himself the problem from the start?"

Different answers, but they had two things in common: both pissed me off, and both were hard to argue with.

"Damn it."

I kicked at the ground. Honestly, I felt a little aggrieved. How was I supposed to have stayed calm in that situation?

A fiancé, out of nowhere.

Just thinking about it made my head spin. Forget a grenade—that was a ballistic missile. My only comfort was the word *former* in front of *fiancé*.

"I told you not to ask," Gung Gibang said.

"If I'd known it would be like this, I wouldn't have asked," I replied with a sigh. "Besides, Young Lady Ju brought it up first."

"Because you made it so obvious you wanted to know."

"Gung Gibang is right. You could have figured there was a reason and left it alone. Why did you have to—"

"The bastard who shit his pants can shut up."

"…Yes, sir."

"I didn't shit my pants," Gung Gibang said, "so I can keep talking."

"Not for long. You'll be shitting blood in a minute."

"…Calm down. Put your fist down first."

The truth was, I didn't have the strength to hit him. At the customer's request, I lowered my fist and stared into space.

"I want to turn back time."

"You can't."

"You can't, Captain."

"Still, I didn't let it show much afterward, did I? I was pretty calm."

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin gave me warm smiles.

"Of course. Couldn't tell at all. Apart from the six times you knocked over your water glass."

"And the seven times you dropped your chopsticks."

"The best part was when the server asked us to add anything else we wanted to the order slip[2506] and you glared at him."

"Seriously, how did you connect an order slip to Sama Pyo? It took me ages to work that out."

"You were practically insane."

"Dark Heaven, at minimum."

"…"

I get it, so stop it, you fucking bastards.

I wanted to beat the hell out of them, but I didn't have the energy. Trudging along was about all I could manage. I couldn't even be bothered to hide my face beneath my crooked bamboo hat, let alone care when people recognized me.

"Th-that man, could he be…?"

"Gasp! It is! It's Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung!"

"But why is he walking like that?"

"How would I know?"

"Looks like a woman dumped him."

"Ha ha. Good one."

"…"

Don't laugh. It's not a joke.

I was taking damage from every direction just by breathing. I sighed and adjusted my bamboo hat, my thoughts still hopelessly tangled.

An ex-boyfriend. No, an ex-fiancé.

[2506] The Korean for "order slip," *jumunpyo*, shares its final syllable, *pyo*, with Sama Pyo's name.

I knew roughly what had happened. Hwaran had told me about her past plainly and without hiding anything.

“It was a political marriage. I hadn’t even seen his face before that.”

Nothing unusual about that. The Yongbong Escort Bureau had been declining day by day, and the Black Dragon Demon Gate had reached out to Hwaran with an offer she couldn’t refuse.

“I made the decision myself. For my father, after he collapsed.”

Her calm voice and expression were still on my mind when someone called to me.

“My youngest.”

I blinked. We were in front of our lodgings. I hadn’t even noticed us arriving.

Jin Wikyung stood before me, a large man, though not quite as enormous as Taishan.

“Great Hero Mae—no, the Alliance Leader is looking for you.”

Chapter 535

"Great Hero Mae—no, the Alliance Leader is looking for you."

Jin Wikyung's sudden announcement stopped me short.

"Me?"

"Yes. And Cheongpung as well."

Cheongpung too?

I was about to ask why when a familiar face popped out of a pavilion window.

"Grandpa! Are we going to see Grandpa now?"

Cheongpung sounded thrilled. Jin Wikyung smiled faintly and shook his head.

"Not your grandfather. The Alliance Leader is looking for you."

"Yes. Grandpa!"

"The same man, but it's different. In any case, Young Hero Cheongpung, get ready and come down as soon as you can."

"Just a moment! I need to pack some dumplings!"

"All right. Take a variety. And some sweets."

He's had some practice, all right. Didn't even blink.

Jin Wikyung had dealt with Cheongpung enough times by now that it came naturally to him.

Cheongpung vanished amid a clatter, and Jin Wikyung turned to me.

"You aren't asking why."

"…I'd say it's more accurate to say I haven't had a chance to ask."

"That's true."

"I might as well hear it from him when I get there. Besides, I already have a feeling."

"What sort of feeling?"

"That he didn't call us over just to see his grandson."

He wanted to see Cheongpung and me.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak—no, the Alliance Leader of the Murim Alliance.

The man was the same, but the title made all the difference. That was probably what Jin Wikyung had meant when he corrected Cheongpung.

The Alliance Leader.

It was a weighty title. The man bearing it carried the countless martial artists crisscrossing the Nine Provinces[2507]—and all of Murim—on his shoulders. And he wanted to see me…

No matter how I look at it, that's ominous.

Had something else happened already?

[2507] The Nine Provinces, or *Jiuzhou*, is a traditional name for the lands of China.

I was wondering just that when—

Whoosh!

Cheongpung appeared with the sound of rushing wind. A bulging silk bundle hung from one hand, and gleaming silver armor covered his upper body.

Wait. Armor?

Hiss.

“I’m back. What the fuck?”

“It’s Mimi. She’s grown so much I can’t carry her in my arms anymore.”

“…Then how about leaving her here?”

Cheongpung tilted his head.

“Why?”

“Do you seriously not know?”

“Yes!”

“Oh… Not a moment’s hesitation. You’re driving me insane.”

She was a snake. A snake with horns, no less.

She’d grown so bulky that *Mimi* hardly seemed like the right name anymore.

Bottom line: I didn’t know how many snake lovers there were in the Murim Alliance, but she wasn’t exactly a pet they’d welcome.

“…What the hell have you been feeding her?”

“Hehe. She’s gotten huge, hasn’t she? Guess, Benefactor.”

I answered without hesitation.

“Steroids.”

“Mostly dumplings and sweets. Oh, she definitely seems to have gotten a lot bigger after eating the Blood Fish.”

I was about to ask why he’d fed a snake dumplings and sweets when I caught myself.

“Blood Fish?”

“Yes.”

Blood Fish were fish from Dongting Lake contaminated by magical power.

In other words, she’d eaten something thoroughly tainted…

“No. Mimi stays here.”

“She’s fine.”

“Other people might not be. She could bite someone.”

“No, Mimi wouldn’t bite even if I told her to. Want to see?”

Looking desperate to prove it, Cheongpung reached toward Mimi.

“Mimi, bite!”

Swish. Clack!

It happened in an instant.

Mimi lunged with her jaws wide open, quick as lightning. Cheongpung's hand vanished even faster.

Her teeth snapped together on empty air. She flicked her tongue as if disappointed.

Hiss.

"See? She didn't bite."

"…"

"…"

Is he insane?

She just missed.

Everyone, myself included, was speechless. Cheongpung's face fell.

"Sal—no, Mungyeong said she was fine…"

"Mungyeong did?"

"Yes. I see him a lot these days. He checked on Mimi, too."

Come to think of it, I hadn't seen much of either Cheongpung or Mungyeong lately. I'd been busy, but from what Cheongpung said, that wasn't the only reason.

That guy never took an interest in anyone else. What's gotten into him?

Cheongpung saw my eyes narrow and caught his breath.

"Gasp."

"Why?"

"It's nothing."

That only made him more suspicious.

But I let it go with a shrug. Jin Wikyung was visibly growing anxious.

"My youngest, that…"

"Oh, sorry. Are we in a hurry?"

"Honestly, it wouldn't be good to arrive late. Others will be waiting too."

Others?

This was turning out to be a bigger gathering than I'd expected.

I hid my unease and jerked my chin toward Cheongpung.

"Let's go, Cheongpung."

"Yes, Benefactor!"

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin nodded, their faces grim.

"Right. Let's go."

"I'll escort you, Captain. And you as well, Lesser Family Head."

"You two shut up and stay here to clean up the grime and shit."

"…"

"…"

The Murim Alliance was like a small city.

At its center stood the Alliance Leader's Hall. We went inside and stopped before a massive door.

"You've arrived."

The guard had a rigid gaze and expression, along with a carefully contained aura.

He was unmistakably a Peak master who had reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy. Yet here, this nameless man was only a doorkeeper.

He appeared to know Jin Wikyung. After greeting him quietly, he opened the door.

Rattle. Rattle. Rattle.

The scraping sounds came one after another. Only after five doors had opened in succession did I see what lay beyond.

Good thing I left those idiots behind.

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin ought to thank me. If they'd followed, they'd be standing here stinking of grime and shit, too scared to open their mouths and sweating buckets.

That was how impressive the people seated around the enormous table were—their faces and auras alike.

"Wow."

A soft exclamation came from beside me. Jin Wikyung poked the wide-eyed Cheongpung in the side and sent a Sound Transmission.

—This is as far as I go.

I understood. I nodded and stepped over the threshold.

Step.

My footsteps echoed through the silence.

Gazes fell on Cheongpung and me—some sharp, some impassive, others full of wonder and curiosity.

"Oh? So these are the youngsters we've heard so much about…"

"They're remarkable, even the second time I've seen them."

"Hm. Not bad."

"What do you mean, not bad? What they've done is extraordinary. A blessing for all of Murim."

The owners of those aged voices sat on either side of us.

Although they had reached supreme realms of martial arts and slowed the aging process, every last hair on their heads was as white as snow. It was enough to give me an idea of how much time they had lived through.

The leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang. And the Family Heads of the Five Great Families.

Fifteen pillars supporting Murim.

They had never all gathered in one place, not even for the Star-Array Grand Banquet—a Murim event on a grand scale. Nor had they managed it at the Mount Song Resolution, when the Murim Alliance was proclaimed. Some had been too far away to arrive in time.

But now, at last…

They're all here.

If the Star-Array Grand Banquet was a feast for stars just beginning to rise, this was a banquet for giants who had carved their names and left their marks on Murim's long history.

Even among them, a few presences stood out.

They no longer headed their families, yet wielded even greater influence. Martial artists throughout the land spoke of them with reverence:

One God, Three Saints, Ten Kings.

Long ago, a hundred-thousand-strong demonic army had surged toward the Central Plains with the blood-red western sky at its back, and heroes had risen to oppose it.

They were swords and spears that cut through the enemy, shields that defended the Central Plains. In time, they became a vast, shining legend.

When the sky that was the Martial God disappeared, the three stars that had lit it vanished one by one. The ten kings stepped down from their thrones and slowly died or grew old. But some had returned to this place.

The Azure Sky Sword King. The Thunderbolt Saber King. And…

There were faces I knew and faces I didn't. One man stood out above them all. When he saw me, his eyebrows rose.

—How long has it been since I called for you? Only showing up now? You must be desperate to die.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

The Sound Transmission was gruff, but there was warmth in it. I couldn't help smiling.

—Look at you. You can smile at a time like this?

What am I supposed to do if it comes out?

—Honestly. You were stiff as a board a moment ago. The Nine Sects and One Gang, the Five Great Families—none of them are anything special. They're all much the same. Our sect is the best.

Who else could say that so freely?

After that proud, arrogant declaration, another Sound Transmission reached me. He hesitated for a moment before continuing.

—So straighten your shoulders and open your eyes wide. You… are this old man's pride.

Pride.

I hadn’t expected that word.

Although he hadn’t said it aloud, I had never imagined Jeok Cheongang would say something like that to me.

I couldn’t hold back. My lips moved.

—Old Master.

Jeok Cheongang had been avoiding my gaze. He flinched.

—Ahem.

—Old Master.

—Wh-Why are you calling me?

—I think it’s time for your medicine.

—You little fucking bastard…

—And thank you.

—…!

Jeok Cheongang’s red eyebrows trembled.

I looked away and straightened my back. The muscles that had tightened throughout my body relaxed, and my head cleared.

I’m someone’s pride.

I still didn’t know why this gathering had been called. But I knew one thing: the confidence I had briefly lost, then found again, was what had brought me here.

Step.

Cheongpung and I stopped together.

The corridor that had seemed so long and distant had ended. There was nowhere left to go.

The voices of the giants, who had been quietly speaking among themselves while watching us, abruptly fell silent as though they had been waiting for this exact moment.

Silence.

A silence waiting for one person, prepared for one person.

At the place of honor among those twenty-odd giants, a man rose. Instead of white hair, he had black, and his eyes were clear.

Rattle.

Three stars had once adorned the sky above the vast world. Of them, the brightest —and now the only one remaining—was Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

He opened his mouth.

No.

Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak.

That was the man standing here. And I wasn’t the only one who understood.

Cheongpung spoke so softly that only I could hear.

“Grandpa…”

A warm smile touched Mae Jonghak’s lips as he looked at us. At the same time, a powerful voice flowed from his mouth.

“The masters of the Two Dragons Pavilion have arrived.”

Chapter 536

Two Dragons Pavilion.

I'd never heard the name before. Yet I knew what Mae Jonghak meant.

The masters of the Two Dragons Pavilion.

Cheongpung and me.

Then Mae Jonghak spoke, his voice calm and commanding.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. Come closer."

His manner was different. So was the air around him.

There was no trace of the man who called me his friend and liked to tease me.

The person before me was neither Always-Victorious Sword Jongni Chu nor Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

Step.

I took a deep breath, stepped forward, and respectfully cupped my hands toward the Alliance Leader.

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan greets you, Alliance Leader."

A light came into Mae Jonghak's eyes as he looked at me.

"For generations, the Jin Family of Taiyuan has stood as a symbol of righteous spirit. It fed the hungry, cared for the sick, and whenever the Central Plains was in danger, its members fought without regard for their own lives."

Three hundred years. A full three hundred years.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan had roots deep and strong enough to earn its place among the great families. It might have swayed, but it had never been uprooted. Its steps might have faltered, but it had never strayed from the righteous path.

"Two years ago, in winter, you personally cut down Blade of Flowers Jin Baekyang, your own blood relative and the family's Head Elder. Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, why was that?"

The leader of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho, who had been standing silently at attention, opened his mouth with a stiff expression.

"Because he was a traitor. He had long been acting on Dark Heaven's orders. He betrayed not only the Jin Family of Taiyuan, but all of Murim."

"Are you certain?"

"I stake my life on it."

He didn't need to stake his life. Everyone here knew the truth. Anyone who paid the slightest attention to news from Murim knew it.

So why spend precious time on something everyone already knew?

I had a good idea.

To remind them. And to make them accept it.

Mae Jonghak's words weren't meant for me alone. His real audience was the twenty-odd giants seated throughout this vast conference hall.

"One year ago, the Star-Array Grand Banquet was held here in Henan, and Dark Heaven's attack stained Shaolin's grounds with blood. What did you do?"

I answered without hesitation.

"I fought."

"Why?"

"That's…"

I closed my mouth.

Why?

The question caught me off guard. Not because I didn't know the answer, but because I'd never once thought about it.

Well. Why did I?

I'd long considered myself selfish and materialistic. That didn't make me a cold-blooded bastard. When people were dying right in front of me, who had time to weigh what was in it for me?

On the day Shaolin was stained with blood, there hadn't been a question mark in my head. Only exclamation marks. I'd run in and fought.

The answer came easily.

"I've never thought about it."

"Why not?"

"Because it was what anyone would do."

"What anyone would do…"

Mae Jonghak repeated my answer softly, then turned his smiling eyes toward his Disciple and sworn grandson.

"Pung. What about you?"

"Me?"

"Were you afraid of dying?"

Cheongpung stared at him with wide, clear eyes before answering hesitantly.

"I was. I'd never thought about death before."

"But you went to Shaolin. Why?"

"…Regret."

"Hmm?"

"I think I would've regretted it for the rest of my life if I'd run away."

His quiet mumble grew clear.

"I felt like I'd lose something greater than my life."

That was right. He'd said the same thing when we fought the Blood Lord.

Cut and torn, bleeding heavily and writhing in pain, Cheongpung had refused to retreat. He'd known he was no match for the Blood Lord, but he kept charging at him.

"What the hell? Why are you acting like you're so desperate to die first?"

And when the Blood Lord had asked him that with confusion and anger, Cheongpung had answered with a clear smile.

"If I retreat… I think I'll regret it for the rest of my life."

That regret. I knew what he meant.

Maybe I'd been more afraid of living alone with that regret than I was of dying.

"Regret. Regret…"

Mae Jonghak muttered quietly, then turned his gaze toward me.

"And you?"

"Me, sir?"

My answer hadn't changed since I first started working as a Hunter.

I gave a short, quiet laugh and answered.

"Death is always scary. I'm afraid of dying."

Was that too honest?

"Ahem. Hm."

A few of the people watching in silence cleared their throats uncomfortably. But Mae Jonghak's smile only deepened.

"Facing the fear of death and helping another in need. That is chivalry."

"…!"

The throat-clearing stopped. The room went still.

A man who had been sitting crookedly in his chair spoke up.

"What anyone would do. Thinking it and doing it are worlds apart, though. And you two did it without hesitation."

There was warmth in his voice. Fire King Jeok Cheongang's eyes were unmistakably smiling as he looked at me.

"That is humanity."

"…!"

Humanity and chivalry. Chivalry and humanity.

Alike in one sense, different in another. Two short words, heavy enough to press down on everyone in the room.

People say a true martial artist does not fear death.

But the world has another name for someone who feels that fear, refuses to yield to it, and acts with humanity and chivalry.

"A knight-errant…"

Someone's murmur rang strangely loud in the silence.

That was when a graying middle-aged man with a faint smile opened his mouth.

"A knight-errant. Now there's a word I like."

His hands were strangely large and thick for a man of his modest build. Only then did I recognize him.

Fist King Yan Hwapyeong.

The last descendant of the Jinzhou Yan Family, which had been utterly ruined long ago by power struggles between orthodox factions.

He had turned his back on the world and lived atop an unnamed mountain. But when news reached him that a hundred thousand demonic soldiers had invaded the Central Plains, he joined the Murim Alliance without hesitation.

"Do you know why the Fist King is such an incredible man?"

"How would I know?"

"I once asked him if he had no pride. The orthodox bastards had ruined his family before he was even born. How many of the men gathered here, I asked him, knew anything about humanity or chivalry?"

"You really have no tact, do you?"

"Shut up and listen. His answer was the best part."

"What did he say?"

"He said it didn't matter."

"What?"

"Just that. None of it mattered. He'd simply come to help. And the moment the Great Faction War ended, he vanished like a phantom. That man was the real thing. Ha ha ha."

That same Fist King Yan Hwapyeong was smiling at us now. It was a warm smile.

"Doing what ought to be done. Overcoming fear and moving forward. That is a knight-errant. Yes, indeed."

He wasn't the only one nodding in approval. Gentle gazes fell on Cheongpung and me from around the room. In the eyes of several familiar faces, I could see unmistakable gratitude.

Myriad-Poison Asura Tang Sadok.

He was pale, as though he hadn't fully recovered, but his back was straight and the green light in his eyes was clear.

Our eyes met. The corner of his wrinkled mouth lifted slightly, and he spoke.

"As Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, I would like to say a few words."

The unexpected announcement drew every eye to him. Mae Jonghak gave a small nod, and Tang Sadok continued in his hissing voice.

"Being a pavilion master of the Murim Alliance is a position of tremendous weight and responsibility. I believe it requires not only outstanding martial arts, but also

the experience to match. It would be unreasonable to entrust it to young people who are not even thirty, let alone forty."

A stir ran through the room. Several expressions shifted. Joy crossed some faces, displeasure others.

But…

The rule about hearing someone out before you judge doesn't just apply to Korean.

Tang Sadok's next words confirmed my suspicion.

"However, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung and Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung are exceptions. They fought Dark Heaven in Shanxi, Henan, Sichuan, and Hubei. They showed us what humanity and chivalry mean. This old man and my family owe them a debt we cannot hope to repay."

Voices of agreement rose around the room.

They belonged to the heads of sects and families who had crossed paths with me personally throughout the Murim, or through Jeok Cheongang or the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Others nodded as though it were only natural, despite having no connection to me at all.

Encouraged by this response, Myriad-Poison Asura Tang Sadok continued in a clear voice.

"If these two take on important positions within the Murim Alliance, who would dare question their qualifications—or object to the Alliance Leader's command?"

He put particular force behind those last words. Several people frowned, among them the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect.

Tang Sadok swept his green-lit gaze across the room, then cupped his hands.

"As you can see, there will be no objections. Alliance Leader, you need only give the order."

He'd ended the argument before anyone could raise it.

And anyone who did object would be taking on the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, one of Murim's most famously uncompromising clans. The Sichuan Blood Tragedy had dealt them a devastating blow, but they were still one of the Five Great Families, with strength no one could afford to dismiss.

"Hmm…"

Someone let out a low groan.

Then a voice broke the brief silence.

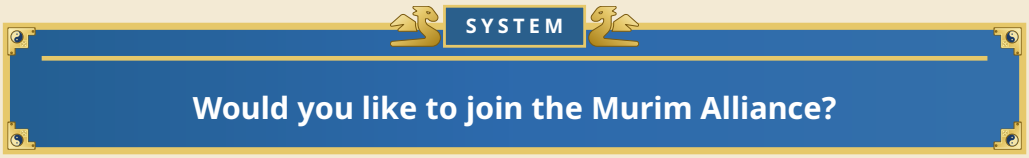
"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung."

Mae Jonghak looked at us warmly.

"I have yet to ask the two of you. Do you wish to join the Two Dragons Pavilion?"

At that moment—

Ding.



The notification appeared before my eyes.

Neither Cheongpung nor I took long to decide. Our eyes met, and we answered as one.

“We do.”

“Then I hereby formally decree this. From this moment onward, the two of you shall belong to the Two Dragons Pavilion, directly under the Alliance Leader’s Office and answerable only to the Alliance Leader’s commands. Each of you shall become a pavilion master, with the authority to select the personnel you require…”

I couldn’t make out what came next. No—I couldn’t hear it properly.

Ding. Ding. Ding, ding!

The bells rang without pause, filling my ears.

Chapter 537

“The tea smells wonderful.”

The first to speak was a graying middle-aged man. He looked at least ten years younger than his actual age, which was past sixty. Yet as he faced the man across the teacups, his expression was tight with tension and displeasure.

“Great Hero Mae. No, Alliance Leader.”

Only someone with a mind at ease could enjoy the fragrance of tea. Unable to contain his impatience any longer, the man spoke again. Sword Saint Mae Jonghak smiled at him.

“I’m listening. What is it?”

“You already know, don’t you? The Thousand-Faced Fox…”

“He’s the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.”

“Yes. And the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion must have reported it to you already.”

“Reported what?”

“If you truly haven’t heard, then I’ll tell you myself.”

If Mae Jonghak meant to play ignorant, he would have to show his hand first. The middle-aged man bit his lip and spoke. He was Hwangbo Gun, Family Head of the Hwangbo Family.

“It concerns my son.”

Mae Jonghak’s eyes widened.

“You have a son?”

“Alliance Leader!”

Hwangbo Gun raised his voice before he could stop himself. Realizing his mistake, he lowered his head.

They might once have fought on the same battlefield, but the man before him was now the Alliance Leader of the Murim Alliance. In the past, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had let almost anything pass with a good-natured smile. An offense against the Alliance Leader, though, could leave the Hwangbo Family in a difficult position.

“I-I apologize. With my son involved, I spoke out of turn.”

Mae Jonghak lifted his teacup with a bright, guileless smile that belied his age.

“Don’t worry about it. These things happen. How many times have we fought together?”

“I’m grateful to hear you say so.”

Hwangbo Gun’s expression brightened a little. Their days on the battlefield were long past, and their positions now stood as far apart as heaven and earth, but Mae Jonghak clearly remembered their bond. Perhaps this would go well after all.

“I’ll get straight to the point. The reason I requested this private audience…”

He quickly recounted what had happened a few shichen[2508] earlier. His account was embellished just enough to differ subtly from the truth, though Hwangbo Gun saw it differently.

How dare they do this!

His only son had come along when he was nearly forty. Hwangbo Gun had looked the other way no matter how much trouble the boy caused, and paid no mind to the endless scandals involving women. Now he had been told that his precious son had suffered every kind of humiliation before a crowd of onlookers.

That, Hwangbo Gun could not overlook.

“How can this be allowed? However far the principles of the martial world have fallen, how dare some spawn of demonic, heterodox arts attack the Lesser Family Head of the Hwangbo Family? And furthermore…”

His voice, thick with anger, suddenly dropped.

“An orthodox martial artist who witnessed such injustice and still protected that spawn of the demonic, heterodox arts could no longer be called orthodox, could he? Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. I’m speaking of that man.”

“Hmm. So that happened.”

Clink.

Mae Jonghak set down his half-empty teacup and tilted his head.

“But what do you want, exactly?”

“Pardon?”

“I’ve heard your account. I understand what happened. Now tell me what you want.”

Hwangbo Gun stared at Mae Jonghak without speaking, then uttered a single word.

“Punishment. I want appropriate punishment.”

“For example?”

“I had my retainers look into it. The man who attacked my son belongs to the Black Dragon Demon Gate in Gansu.”

“The Black Dragon Demon Gate. I see. Very well.”

Mae Jonghak nodded at once. Hwangbo Gun’s expression brightened. Convinced the Alliance Leader had taken his side, he went on with renewed force.

“And I believe Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung should be disciplined as well.”

“Disciplined…”

“You’ve heard what happened. He sided with those demonic, heterodox martial artists even after seeing the attack with his own eyes.”

[2508] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

"I suppose so."

"And such a man is a pavilion master of the Murim Alliance. I'm not the only one who finds that deeply regrettable."

Regrettable was the mildest word Hwangbo Gun could bring himself to use. This was what infuriated him most.

That young punk is a pavilion master?

A pavilion master was no ordinary post. It placed its holder among the Murim Alliance's twenty highest-ranking members and carried the authority to command multiple groups and squads.

He's directly under the Alliance Leader's Office, so he can't have subordinate units of his own. But he's still a pavilion master. How does that make any sense?

Even his son, considered one of Murim's foremost young prodigies, might or might not receive a Squad Leader's post. Jin Taekyung had already been raised far above that. And the Jin Family of Taiyuan's growing influence had lately reached as far as Shandong, where the Hwangbo Family was based. Hwangbo Gun had to put a stop to this, whatever it took.

"The Huashan Divine Dragon's appointment as pavilion master is a blessing for Murim. I welcome it wholeheartedly. But Jin Taekyung…"

He deliberately trailed off and glanced at Mae Jonghak. The conversation had gone well so far; surely the Alliance Leader understood what he meant.

Mae Jonghak's answer exceeded even his hopes.

"Now that I think about it, you have a point. I'll consider not only disciplining him, but taking personnel action as well."

"Th-Thank you, Alliance Leader!"

Discipline *and* personnel action? Hwangbo Gun had never expected it to go this well. As he bowed again and again, Mae Jonghak watched him with a smile, then murmured,

"The teacup is empty."

"Pardon? Oh."

"Time passes quickly these days."

Hwangbo Gun froze for a moment. Then he understood and stood. Family Head or not, he could hardly take up more of the Alliance Leader's time. The time allotted for their private audience—the time it took to drink a cup of tea—had already passed.

"I seem to have stayed too long. Ha ha."

"Hmm? You're leaving?"

Even that polite attempt to keep him there warmed Hwangbo Gun's heart. He had gained more than he'd hoped for, and he appreciated Mae Jonghak's consideration for his dignity. The bond they had forged during the Great Faction War felt stronger than ever.

“I can’t take up any more of your valuable time. I’ll take my leave, Alliance Leader.”

“Then I suppose it can’t be helped.”

“Yes. I’ll be going.”

“Take care. I’ll see you again.”

Pat, pat.

Someone else might have offended Hwangbo Gun by patting the Family Head of the Hwangbo Family on the shoulder. But this was the Number One Sword Under Heaven, the Alliance Leader of the Murim Alliance. Hwangbo Gun left with a broad smile.

Moments later—

Clack.

The door opened, and a man entered the office. His prosthetic leg made a dull sound as he walked.

“For the Family Head of the Hwangbo Family to request a private audience over something like this… He must have been desperate.”

“That fellow seems to have neglected his martial arts training. His personality has changed a little, too.”

“Pardon?”

“It’s nothing. Sit down.”

Mae Jonghak looked at the hand he had used to pat Hwangbo Gun’s shoulder, then offered his visitor a seat.

The Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho, cast a brief glance at the teacup Hwangbo Gun had not even half emptied before speaking.

“Some people are unhappy with the recent appointments.”

“Hmm. Is that so?”

“They met in secret before the Hwangbo Family Head requested his audience.”

“That can happen.”

“Rather than oppose you directly, they seem to have urged him on.”

“Come to think of it, Hwangbo Gun always did tend to put himself forward. He even stood at the vanguard during the battle in Guizhou.”

“…Hoo.”

Mae Jonghak’s eyes widened at Song Ho’s sigh.

“Hmm? What is it?”

“That’s not what I’m talking about.”

“In the end, aren’t we talking about people? Ha ha.”

Song Ho started to answer, then paused.

Mae Jonghak wasn't wrong. It came down to who did what, and how. Now and then, he would toss off a remark like that, and Song Ho would sense a depth of insight in it.

"In any case, you made the Hwangbo Family Head a promise you can't keep."

"A promise?"

"Didn't you say you would discipline the Black Dragon Demon Gate and the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, and take appropriate personnel action?"

"Ah, yes. I did. I'm thinking about that now."

"Alliance Leader, you can't—"

"Wait. Give me a moment."

Mae Jonghak scratched his chin. A moment later, he spoke again.

"All right. I'm done. Then let's pretend the whole thing never happened."

"Pardon?"

"I've considered it, and I don't think personnel action is necessary. There should be some discipline, but I can decide on that later."

"…!"

Song Ho stared at him, his eyes trembling, then let out a disbelieving laugh.

"Of course. You only said you would consider it, Alliance Leader."

"Even so, he was once a comrade I fought alongside. Shouldn't I keep my promise?"

"The Hwangbo Family Head is going to clutch the back of his neck."

"Oh. Don't you think he'll understand?"

"Ha ha. I wonder."

"I was sincere. If he doesn't understand, there's nothing I can do."

Song Ho struggled to hold back his laughter. Mae Jonghak was far better suited to the role of Alliance Leader than he had expected. He was so easygoing by nature that he could let almost anything pass with *That can happen.* However hard others pressed him, the pressure never seemed to touch him.

His inner resolve is upright and firm.

He was more than Song Ho had hoped for. Song Ho addressed him with genuine feeling.

"Alliance Leader."

"What is it?"

"I just felt like calling you."

"Hmm. That can happen."

"Ha ha ha!"

Mae Jonghak tilted his head at Song Ho's laughter.

“Oh, right. How are matters with the Nanman Beast Palace and the North Sea Ice Palace?”

Song Ho’s smile faded.

“Neither has replied yet. We sent the letters to both earlier than planned, but they’re a long way off…”

“I see.”

“Yes. But as you know, things are going well with the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League. Both Alliance Leaders have said they’ll come to Henan in person.”

Neither organization belonged to the orthodox faction, but their leaders were unquestionably giants of the martial world. They commanded forces to rival the great sects and had outstanding masters among their ranks.

“They’ll be a great help if they join us.”

Mae Jonghak gave a small nod, then spoke again.

“Oh. About the discipline.”

“The discipline? Ah, yes.”

“I’ll dictate it. Write a letter and deliver it to the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—no, to Pavilion Master Jin.”

“As you command.”

Song Ho cupped his hands respectfully. Jin Taekyung’s role from here on would be crucial. Even if the punishment was severe, he had to remain a pavilion master.

I couldn’t believe my eyes or ears.

“Discipline? For me?”

The martial artist from the Alliance Leader’s Office nodded.

“Yes.”

“Why all of a sudden? And this punishment is too harsh.”

“I’ve delivered the message. I’ll be going.”

Whoosh!

What kind of situation is this supposed to be?

I stared blankly after him as he vanished like the wind. Hyuk Mujin came over and asked cautiously,

“Discipline? What did they say?”

I let out a long sigh.

“I have to go hungry.”

“Pardon?”

“I have to skip dinner.”

“…?”
“Ugh, I was going to have roast duck tonight.”
I grumbled under my breath and kicked Hyuk Mujin in the butt.
“Enough. Let’s go.”
“What kind of punishment is that? And where are we going?”
“To recruit some teammates.”
“Whaaat?”

Chapter 538

I looked at Hyuk Mujin, whose eyes had gone wide.

“What are you so surprised about? Once you become a pavilion master, of course you need to recruit people.”

“No, that’s true, but…”

“But what?”

Hyuk Mujin stared at me in disbelief.

“I’m more concerned about the punishment. What’s with that bizarre order? It’s like a children’s prank.”

“I hear our Alliance Leader personally issued that bizarre, prank-like order.”

“Hmm. On second thought, the punishment must have some profound meaning. Food, clothing, and shelter are the most important things in life. To order you to skip dinner, of all things, must carry some deeper significance…”

“…”

Don’t force meaning onto it, you idiot.

They say that once you’re famous, people will applaud even when you take a shit. That fit this situation perfectly.

I gave Hyuk Mujin a long look. He’d changed his tune the instant I mentioned Mae Jonghak.

“You think it’s bullshit too.”

“…Yes.”

“Then shut up and follow me. And stop worrying about the punishment.”

I shook my head, opened the door, and stepped outside. Hyuk Mujin hurried after me, muttering as he went.

“Wouldn’t it be stranger *not* to worry? You were appointed pavilion master less than two shichen[2509] ago, and you’re already being punished. Did you take a dump in the Alliance Leader’s room?”

Coming from the guy who’d singled me out as the only person who could have taken a dump in a crowded inn. I clicked my tongue.

“Filthy idea. Creative, though. You’re close, but wrong.”

“Close but wrong? Did you pee in there?”

…This bastard.

I held back the urge to punch him and answered.

“Apparently, some people feel shitty about me becoming a pavilion master.”

“Oh.”

[2509] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are approximately four hours.

"Well, that's how the world works."

Pavilion Master of the Two Dragons Pavilion.

That was my official title.

At first, I'd been pleasantly surprised by how cool it sounded. Then I'd learned that a pavilion master of the Murim Alliance held a far more important position than I'd imagined.

I had no idea it was this big a deal.

The title carried that much weight.

A regiment fell directly under a pavilion master, along with the various squads that made up the regiment. Given the Murim Alliance's current size, the position could mean commanding anywhere from several hundred to more than a thousand martial artists.

Not a position someone my age could even dream of.

Until now, the Murim's organizational structure hadn't been my concern.

If I had to put something on my résumé, I'd served as captain of a reconnaissance unit when war broke out between the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect. That was about it.

Afterward…

I wandered all over the damn place.

Maybe I was born under a wandering star. Ever since I'd finished my year of training on Mount Jiuhua and come down from the mountain, I'd done little but travel. Sometimes I couldn't tell whether I was a martial artist or a traveling peddler.

But my long freelance career had ended today.

The problem was that several company executives weren't happy about my promotion to full-time employee.

"Who do you think they are?" Mujin asked.

"Who else?"

"Hmm. A few names do come to mind…"

"Then you've got your answer. It's one of them."

The Hwangbo Family was probably the biggest reason for this punishment, but I didn't need to spell out every detail for Hyuk Mujin.

I expected something like this, anyway.

Even the kindest, friendliest person in the world couldn't avoid jealous looks. Someone as round as a balloon would still get knocked this way and that. So what chance did a sharp-edged, sixteen-sided polygon like me have?

No. This is better.

A balloon lost its air when people came at it with words or weapons. Better to be a sixteen-sided polygon that didn't take so much as a scratch.

That was how Jin Taekyung had lived, and that was how he would keep living.

“If they keep poking at me, I’ll just smash them.”

“What?”

“Nothing. Let’s go.”

I lightly smacked the back of Hyuk Mujin’s head as he stared at me in confusion, then kept walking.

The news of the Murim Alliance’s new young pavilion master must have already spread, because the gazes of the martial artists walking along the main road were burning with interest.

“See him over there? That’s Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung…”

“Shh. Don’t call him by name so casually. Haven’t you heard? He’s a pavilion master of the great Murim Alliance now.”

“Oh, come on. Does that matter? Don’t pick a fight over nothing. He’s barely twenty—young enough to be my son. He’s just a kid.”

The middle-aged martial artist’s companion clicked his tongue.

“A kid? Has all that martial arts training hardened your brain?”

“What did you say?”

“Just look at yourself, Brother. You’ve joined the Murim Alliance too, haven’t you? Then Great Hero Jin is practically your superior. And you may be old enough to have a son, but you don’t look like you have one.”

“Well, that’s true, but… Why bring that up?”

“Because I don’t want to get dragged down with you. The Enforcement Hall’s martial artists are patrolling Henan with their eyes wide open. I’d rather not be hauled away for insulting a superior just because I was standing next to you.”

The middle-aged martial artist scowled.

“Are you picking a fight with me?”

“I’m not—oh, forget it. No wonder you’re still unmarried at your age. Watch that loose mouth of yours.”

“Fine. I will, you fucker.”

“What was that? You goddamn son of a bitch…”

Are these people insane? How do they even manage to fight like that?

What are they, some kind of battle species?

Maybe the planet Murim was on was actually Planet Vegeta.[2510]

Armed with that perfectly reasonable suspicion, I scanned the crowd for yellow hair. More whispers drifted my way.

“What do you think? Should I make an impression on him now?”

“Are you thinking of applying to the Two Dragons Pavilion?”

[2510] Planet Vegeta is the homeworld of the battle-loving Saiyans in *Dragon Ball*. The reference to yellow hair recalls their golden-haired Super Saiyan form.

“Hmm. I’m considering it. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon is much younger than me, but they say his martial arts already rival those of the great sects’ Sect Leaders.”

“Could he really be that strong? And even if the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon’s martial arts are as impressive as the rumors say, you should stay away.”

“Why?”

“Think carefully about everything the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon has done until now. Even if he has the worst luck in the world, how does he manage to choose nothing but deadly situations every time he moves? Accomplishing great deeds is all well and good, but if someone at our level joined the Two Dragons Pavilion, whew.”

“Still, shouldn’t we try to accomplish something?”

“If you want to put up your tombstone first, go ahead. Besides, the Two Dragons Pavilion has two pavilion masters. You might be better off with the Huashan Divine Dragon. Isn’t he the youngest Disciple the Alliance Leader raised like his own grandson? The Alliance is bound to look after him.”

“You might die even faster there.”

“Hm? Why?”

“I heard the snake the Huashan Divine Dragon keeps with him bites people.”

“…Oh dear.”

Word traveled fast.

If this were modern times, the Murim Alliance would have an online petition board by now.

> The Huashan Divine Dragon’s snake bit me in the crotch. I demand punishment. Please lend me your support.
>
> └ **Thousand-Faced Fox*:** Agreed.
>
> └ **Gung Gi*:** Agreed.
>
> └ **Jeok Cheon*:** □□[2511], that, snake, bastard, I knew, it would do something like this one day,,!
>
> └ **Cheong*:** That’s not true. Mimi doesn’t bite people.
>
> └ **Tang Sa*:** Ah, Mimi…

Once the comments piled up and ten thousand people signed in favor of punishment, Mimi’s fate would be sealed. Hmm.

That was when I was spreading my imagination’s wings.

“Was it about half an hour ago? I heard a commoner passing down the main road saw the snake, panicked, and fell while backing away. He was hurt a little.”

“Oh dear. What happened then?”

[2511] □□ (*kk*) is Korean internet shorthand for laughter, similar to “lol.”

“I heard that some young medical apprentice who was with the Huashan Divine Dragon took him to a medical clinic. Since it happened because he startled himself, it isn’t that serious—ugh.”

The martial artist cut himself off with a gasp.

I’d come up within a step of him. His eyes shook as he stared at me.

“G-Great Hero Jin?”

“Ah, don’t be startled. It’s nothing serious. I just wanted to ask you something.”

“W-What is it?”

“Where’s that clinic?”

“The clinic? Ah, go straight down that way…”

Still stiff with surprise, he raised a hand to point it out.

I gave him a small nod of thanks and turned in the direction he indicated. Hyuk Mujin looked puzzled.

“Why are we going to a clinic all of a sudden?”

“I told you. I’m looking for a teammate.”

“What? Cheongpung?”

“…How would that work?”

This wasn’t going to be some Cheongpung team without Cheongpung. Cheongpung was a pavilion master in his own right now. I couldn’t put him under my command.

“Think before you speak. Think.”

“Then who else at the clinic could you possibly recruit besides Cheong—”

Hyuk Mujin stopped. His eyes widened.

“No way. You can’t mean…”

“Who knows?”

I left him with that and quietly spoke in my mind.

Open the Quest Window.

Ding.

A cheerful chime sounded, and a translucent holographic window appeared in midair.

It was the first Quest I’d received upon joining the Murim Alliance as Pavilion Master of the Two Dragons Pavilion.

SYSTEM

Quest
Become My Companion!
At last, you have become a member of the Murim Alliance and been appointed Pavilion Master of the Two Dragons Pavilion.
However, one person cannot be an organization. The Murim Alliance has therefore entrusted you with the authority to appoint personnel.
Find new members as quickly as possible, form your organization, and give it a name. Only then will you become a pavilion master in the truest sense!
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission:
Secure at least five companions (Incomplete)
Give the organization an appropriate name (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: Acquire the Title “Loner”

“…”

Look at that Title. Fuck.

If I failed this Quest, I’d be an outsider officially recognized by the System.

I had to succeed. And with all the trouble ahead, I needed to choose my members carefully.

Leave out anyone who’d follow me without being asked. I need someone I can persuade to come over first—and someone who’ll be a big help.

That was what came to mind the instant I checked the Quest. And I didn’t have to think for long.

The first person I should recruit had practically been decided from the start.

His personality’s pretty damn nasty, but…

He could help in all kinds of ways.

Whatever. Might as well try.

I took a deep breath and headed for the clinic.

“Tony Tony Cho[2512]—no, Mungyeong. Become my companion!”

That lunatic’s acting up again.

[2512] “Tony Tony Cho” begins the name Tony Tony Chopper, the reindeer doctor in *One Piece*. Taekyung cuts himself off before saying Mungyeong’s name.

Mungyeong wasn’t even surprised anymore. Jin Taekyung was always like this.

Jin Taekyung had called Mungyeong out of the blue, saying that the two of them had something to discuss privately, only to start spouting nonsense.

“No.”

“What? Why not?”

Asking *why* was ridiculous. There were more reasons than Mungyeong could count. But right now, he had a better answer.

“I’ve already agreed to join another group.”

“…What?”

“You got here a step too late. Isn’t that right?”

“Uh, sorry, Benefactor.”

A figure appeared with the sudden voice. Jin Taekyung’s eyes widened as he looked at Cheongpung.

Chapter 539

The Slaughter Saint.

He had entered the world as an assassin, despised by all, and risen at last to become a star that lit the heavens.

He had torn down the fence that admitted only a chosen few, becoming living proof of the four words *Might Makes Right*.

Yet most people knew neither his age nor his face—not even his name. Assassins worked in the deepest secrecy. They did not reveal themselves.

Decades passed, and the veil over the Slaughter Saint never lifted.

The Slaughter Saint had vanished without a trace immediately after the war ended. He did not show himself even once for a long time, and the words that spilled from the mouths of ordinary people traveled a thousand li, ten thousand li,[2513] without needing feet.

The Slaughter Saint is dead!

That was half true and half false.

On the day the Martial God defeated the Heavenly Demon and a hundred thousand demon soldiers fell, an old man in a bamboo hat buried something on an unnamed hill before walking away.

It was not only his beloved weapon, stained with blood. He buried the name Slaughter Saint with it.

The Slaughter Saint died, and Mungyeong emerged into the world. In time, the world began calling him by another name.

The Divine Physician.

The Yangtze has many tributaries, but all their waters join the same river.

Mungyeong was a river like that, bearing two names: the greatest assassin in history and the greatest physician under heaven.

To put it simply…

My number-one recruitment target.

That more than qualified him for a place aboard my Going Murim ship.[2514]

Sure, spending time with him meant the occasional attempt on my life. But I'd rather shit blood a few times than die because we ran into a monster like the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Black cat, white cat. As long as it caught mice, what did the color matter?

[2513] This uses the Chinese *li*, approximately 500 m (0.311 mi). A thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi); ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,110 mi).

[2514] "Going Murim" plays on the Going Merry, the ship in the manga and anime series *One Piece*.

It was a shame my first recruitment target wasn't a cute little deer with horns, but a former assassin who wanted to kill me roughly three times a day. I didn't have much choice.

Who cares about his personality? He has the strongest damage output and healer abilities, too.

Right. That was enough.

In this harsh Murim, where I couldn't even get my hands on a cheap potion, I needed Mungyeong. Even if he never saved me, he might save someone traveling with us when their life was in danger.

The problem was that, in my confidence, I'd overlooked one person.

"Hehe."

"…?"

"Hello, Benefactor."

"…!"

Hello, my ass. What was going on?

No way.

I stared at Cheongpung, my eyes trembling, and finally managed to speak.

"…Why are you coming out of there?"

"Oh, well. I was passing by earlier."

"No, I know why you came here. I mean—"

This was driving me insane. Seriously.

Mungyeong watched me stammer without a trace of expression and answered for him.

"I told you. You were a step too late."

Cheongpung smiled brightly.

"Hehe. That's how it happened, Benefactor."

It was the one blow that turned my suspicion into certainty. I looked back and forth between them in silence for a moment before managing to part my lips.

"Is this for real?"

Mungyeong nodded.

"It probably isn't a legend."

"Then it really happened?"

"Yes. It really happened."

"Why?"

"I have no reason to tell you."

"Fair enough. But I think I could give up gracefully if I heard it from you."

Mungyeong clicked his tongue.

"You're making an ugly business of it."

"What if I still want to hear it, even if I have to be filthy?"

"Then I'll have to find a cleaner way to settle it."

Shing.

Something silver glinted at the end of his long sleeve. I rubbed my eyes at the sight of the short sword that had popped out like a jack-in-the-box.

"Maybe I'm tired and my eyes are going bad. Why is *that* coming out now?"

"Because using this would be clean."

"Maybe, but wouldn't it make a mess around here?"

"That doesn't matter. I know a number of methods."

"…"

He must have picked up a few tricks in all his years as an assassin. I had no desire whatsoever to see any of them firsthand.

"Whew. I'll be going."

"Go. Forever."

"See you later, Benefactor!"

I turned away after those two very different farewells.

This is driving me crazy.

Cheongpung had beaten me to it. I hadn't seen that coming at all.

The Cheongpung I knew should have had a meat dumpling in one hand and a vegetable dumpling in the other, trying to decide which to eat first.

Did he put points into Intelligence instead of me…?

Nothing for it. I'd have to move fast and recruit other people first.

Hyuk Mujin was loitering by the clinic entrance. He hurried over when he spotted me.

"Did it go well—… From your face, I'm guessing not."

Hyuk Mujin blinked after hurriedly correcting himself upon seeing my face.

"I don't see Mungyeong. Does that mean…?"

"Can't you tell?"

"Huh. He turned down the Captain's offer? He's better at judging a situation than he looks— I mean, I'm joking. Please, I'm begging you. Put your fist down."

"Make one more joke and it will become your last will."

Hyuk Mujin backed away to secure a safe distance before speaking in a solemn voice.

"There is one way."

"A way?"

"Yes."

He sounded so sure of himself that I couldn't help listening. I was grasping at a rotten rope, but I asked anyway.

"What is it?"

"How about I try talking some sense into him? That fellow Mungyeong would do anything I say."

"…"

Hangs on your words, my ass. He'd kill you in the blink of an eye.

If Mungyeong wished, he could turn Hyuk Mujin into a corpse with a single inhale and reduce him to powder with a single exhale.

"Mujin…"

"Don't worry. We've built up a fair amount of affection over the years. If Gung and I go and persuade him, he won't refuse us coldly."

"That's not it, you bastard…"

This bastard was actually trying to commit group suicide now.

I looked at Hyuk Mujin with pity.

"You really hate brothels, huh?"

"What?"

"Never mind. Anyway, don't try to marry him—no, persuade him. Absolutely not."

"Why?"

"Just don't, you bastard."

Hyuk Mujin did not know Mungyeong's true identity, so there was no way their conversation could go anywhere.

I sighed at his aggrieved expression.

"Can you write?"

"Write? I'd make Wang Xizhi[2515] weep."

"Answer properly before I beat you until you cry."

"…I write well enough. Believe it or not, people called me a prodigy when I was little."

"Then write out a few big notices and put one up."

"A notice?"

"Yeah. If it's come to this, we might as well look for some real talent."

The world was vast, and masters were plentiful.

Henan, right now, was a prince's residence[2516] teeming with dragons and tigers.

What's so special about holding a public audition?

If you thought about it, even the imperial examinations were the most traditional audition program in existence. With my fame and eye for talent, it was worth trying.

I pictured applicants flooding in.

[2515] Wang Xizhi was a fourth-century Chinese calligrapher celebrated for his skill.

[2516] A prince's residence was his home before he took the throne. Here it suggests a gathering place for people who may become great figures.

Let’s do it. Fuck it.

Shik, sssshk!

The movements were fast and fluid, unlike anything the onlookers had seen before. Whenever his hands moved as if dancing, the tip of the large needle flashed, and thread stitched the wound closed.

In mere moments, a swordsman who had been slowly dying from a deep slash across his abdomen had a chance to live.

“How can someone so young possess medical skills of this level…!”

“I’ve never even heard of a medical apprentice like him.”

“Good heavens. That’s nearly divine!”

The gathered physicians, from heavily bearded middle-aged men to white-haired elders, stared in astonishment. A voice snapped them back to their senses.

“Finished.”

Tap.

The treatment was over in a flash. More astonishing than its speed was the fact that it had been done perfectly.

Mouths agape, the physicians turned to the speaker as he rose from his seat.

“H-How can this be?”

“Hey!”

He looked too young to call a young man, yet something about him made *boy* seem wrong as well.

Mungyeong gathered his belongings and stood.

“Are there any patients left?”

The physicians exchanged glances, then shook their heads all at once.

“N-No, but…”

“Th-That’s right. It’s all thanks to you.”

This was hardly the first time the young medical apprentice had astonished them.

About one shichen[2517] earlier, he had arrived with a patient whose injuries were minor. He’d taken one look at the people lying there and remarked:

“This won’t take long.”

Then he’d begun treating them one by one, so quickly and so thoroughly that the physicians who’d come over to scold him and throw him out couldn’t tear themselves away.

Can medicine like this truly exist?

Who is he?

[2517] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

They had waited until now to ask about his identity. But when they finally did, the young medical apprentice's answer was utterly calm.

"Then that settles it. I'll be going now."

"W-Wait! I have a mountain of questions for you!"

"What is your master's name? Could it be…?"

Questions came at him from every side. Mungyeong inclined his head slightly.

"If I have time, I'll stop by once more before I leave and check on the patients."

"You may have been free to enter, but you're not free to leave!"

"Grab him!"

"Forgive me! We can't let you go like this!"

Whoosh! Crash!

The physicians threw themselves at him, but their hands closed on empty air. They didn't so much as brush his collar before tumbling across the floor.

As they stared about in confusion, Mungyeong's voice rang out.

"I left a prescription for each patient where I was sitting. Read them and carry out the treatments as written."

"W-What? Prescriptions?"

"Where? Where are they?"

To physicians, a renowned doctor's prescriptions were like a peerless master's martial arts manual.

Their eyes all but rolling back, the physicians launched into a fierce struggle over the dozens of prescriptions. Mungyeong slipped outside and walked on, then spoke without warning.

"Come out."

Swish.

With a faint rustle, a figure emerged from behind a large pillar.

"Oh! How did you know?"

"Just because."

"You really are amazing. I thought I'd fool you this time. Hehe."

Mungyeong studied Cheongpung's cheerful face.

"What martial art was that?"

"A footwork technique."

"I know that."

"Oh. I named it Mimi Step."

"Mimi Step?"

"Yes. After our Mimi. Isn't it great?"

Cheongpung's eyes shone. Mungyeong's reply was cold.

"…What an utterly ridiculous name."

"Oh. Ah…"

Cheongpung wilted. Mungyeong watched him, his gaze deepening.

What is with this boy?

The name Mimi Step might be ridiculous, but there was nothing ridiculous about the principles behind those movements.

He created a martial art from the way a snake moves.

Most martial artists spent their entire lives trying to understand a single martial art well enough to make it their own. The boy before him had done that as though it were nothing.

Then, having made it his own, he had recreated it entirely.

This boy… has the makings of a Grandmaster.

Jin Taekyung wasn't the only genius. In some ways, this boy's genius far surpassed his.

Sword Saint, you've raised a monster.

Mungyeong muttered inwardly, then spoke to Cheongpung, who was still looking dejected.

"So why did you offer me your hand?"

"Hmm. Because Benefactor is so amazing."

"Jin Taekyung?"

"Yes. I used to hope Benefactor would catch up with me soon, but… now I feel like he's getting farther away, little by little."

"I see."

Mungyeong understood at once. A genius who had never had anyone to measure himself against was burning with competitive spirit for the first time.

"Are you hoping to learn martial arts from me?"

"No. You don't have to teach me."

"What?"

"I'll watch and learn from you. That's enough. Hehe."

"…!"

Mungyeong paused, then gave a quiet laugh.

What an absurd boy. He meant to learn just by watching—and the martial arts he intended to watch were *Mungyeong's*.

Yet Mungyeong didn't mind.

"Oh! You smiled."

"…I did not."

"You did. You smiled."

"You impudent little brat."

"Oh. Now you're angry."

"…Brat."

"Would you like some dumplings?"

Mungyeong hesitated, wondering whether to draw his short sword. Instead, he took the dumpling Cheongpung offered and bit into it.

The taste was not bad.

Chapter 540

They say words have no feet, yet travel a thousand li.[2518]

And these days, Henan Province was boiling like a cauldron over a charcoal fire.

Under countless watchful eyes, news that two exceptionally young Divine Dragons had been appointed pavilion masters by special order of the Alliance Leader swept across Henan before two days had passed.

“Have you heard the news?”

“I’ve already heard it, so don’t tell me. Even that yellow dog in the back alley probably knows.”

Whenever two or more people gathered, they talked about the appointments.

Opinions were divided, but many martial artists viewed Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung’s appointments favorably.

“Pavilion masters, huh? Of course. Those two are more than qualified.”

“Still, considering their ages, haven’t they been given too much responsibility?”

“That’s what makes it so impressive. Who else could achieve that kind of might and merit at barely twenty?”

“Now that you mention it, you’re right.”

“Damn it. I can’t stand listening to this.”

“…And who might you be, Brother?”

“Come on. Some people are born into good families, find good masters, learn peerless martial arts, and now they get to be pavilion masters of the Murim Alliance too?”

“By your logic, every young prodigy from the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families would be a Supreme Peak master. And why are you taking it out on us?”

“I got pissed off listening to you, so I butted in.”

But where there was light, there was shadow.

Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung inspired envy as well as admiration. That was true not only of wandering martial artists who had lived rough lives, but also of disciples from prestigious sects and families.

“Damn it. How does this make any sense?”

“There’s nothing we can do. The Alliance Leader himself issued the order. Our Sect Leader told us in no uncertain terms not to say a word about it.”

“And what about you?”

“What good would saying anything do? I’m only a third-generation Disciple. One of

[2518] In this Chinese setting, one li is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

my fellow disciples ran his mouth a few shichen[2519] ago and paid for it. Our Senior Martial Uncle was furious. He ordered everyone between him and me to assemble, and…"

"I can imagine."

"Some lunatic even summoned our Master. That really set the mood. We got chewed out until our souls hurt. We even had to hear what we were doing with ourselves when the much younger Blazing Flame Divine Dragon and Huashan Divine Dragon were doing so well."

"What kind of nonsense is that? Why blame us because those two are monsters?"

"Exactly. It's not as if they managed it themselves."

"Wait. Don't tell me…"

"Are you crazy? I didn't say it. But before anyone could stop him, the lunatic who'd summoned our Master came out with it: 'Their masters are the Fire King and the Sword Saint.'"

"Good heavens. Did I hear that right? Look at my arm. I've got goose bumps."

"You think you're bad? Imagine how I and the other Senior Brothers felt after hearing it directly. Even now, I've got goose bumps all the way down to my balls."

"Just so we're clear, you don't need to show me."

"…I wouldn't show you even if you begged. Anyway, things are tense because of those two. Though probably not as tense as they are in the Hwangbo Family."

By then, everyone had heard the rumor that the Shandong Fist Dragon—the Lesser Family Head of the Hwangbo Family and one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes—had suffered a spectacular disgrace.

He had since been appointed Commander of the Murim Alliance's Outer Hall. Between that post and Jin Taekyung's position as a pavilion master directly under the Alliance Leader's Office lay a gulf as wide as heaven and earth.

"I heard the Hwangbo Family Head met privately with the Alliance Leader and demanded punishment…"

"He went around telling everyone himself, so it's probably true. As for the result, you already know."

Hwangbo Gun, the Family Head of the Hwangbo Family, had proudly bragged about his private meeting with the Alliance Leader. Before even half a day had passed, the disciplinary decision arrived, and he had to swallow his humiliation.

> I. Jin Taekyung, Pavilion Master of the Two Dragons Pavilion, privately took one side despite witnessing the dispute before him. He is therefore ordered to fast for a limited period.

[2519] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours. Half a shichen is about one hour.

> II. Taishan of the Black Dragon Demon Gate committed two offenses.
>
> His first offense was causing a dispute on a main road and harming commoners. His second was disregarding the Alliance's rules and wielding a weapon first, thereby failing to follow proper procedure.
>
> However, eyewitness accounts and testimony establish some justification for his actions. He is ordered to pay each person who suffered losses as a result of his actions ten times the amount of their damages.
>
> III. The offense committed by the Shandong Fist Dragon, Hwangbo Ak, is similar to Taishan's.
>
> However, because he was substantially responsible for causing the dispute and made remarks liable to cause trouble, he is ordered to remain under disciplinary confinement for a fixed period.

For Hwangbo Gun, it was enough to drive him mad.

The next day, a rumor spread that Jin Taekyung had polished off ten bowls of gukbap[2520] in one sitting and patted his stomach. That only made matters worse.

The orthodox purists who supported Hwangbo Gun voiced their discontent too. But the shadow cast by the giant known as the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was deep, and they could hardly defy the Alliance Leader's authority over something like this. They had no choice but to swallow their anger.

Amid all that admiration and envy, Jin Taekyung made another extraordinary move just a day after his appointment as Pavilion Master of the Two Dragons Pavilion.

It began with a single notice pasted conspicuously on a wall beside a busy main road.

"Have you seen it?"

"If you mean the news about the Two Dragons Pavilion, I've heard enough to make my ears bleed. Wait. *Seen* what?"

"About half a shichen ago, some fellow named Hyuk—Hyuk something—put up huge notices all along the main roads."

"Why would I care what Hyuk-whatsisname did?"

"Because that Hyuk-whatsisname is Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung's right-hand man. I read the notice, and apparently the Two Dragons Pavilion is recruiting people."

"What? Is that true?"

[2520] Gukbap is rice served in a bowl of hot soup, a common Korean meal.

“Without a doubt. But the notice is… strange. There are other people here, too, and… No, the whole thing is strange.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“It’s, well… Never mind. Go see and hear it for yourself.”

“…Hear it?”

These days, any news about the Two Dragons Pavilion was a hot topic in Henan.

And now the youngest pavilion master—whose genius and accomplishments were rare even in Murim’s long history—had done something else?

“Ah, I can’t miss this!”

Martial artists with affiliations, martial artists still looking for a place to belong, and even curious commoners came rushing over.

And when they gathered in one place, they finally saw it.

⋆I Was a Nameless Foot Soldier, but in the Two Dragons Pavilion, I’m a Murim Hero?!⋆

The words were written in enormous letters beside a bizarre emblem.

The people gathered before it like clouds all widened their eyes and cried out in astonishment.

“Th-That!”

“Good heavens!”

How could a phrase be so simple, so easy to grasp, and so bold? The lines beneath it caught the eye just as readily.

Recruitment Requirements

First: Someone with the passion to do whatever they set their mind to.

Second: An upright character.

Third: At least the level of injuring others with Sword Energy.

Recruiting around the clock # No one below Peak need apply # Gender and sect affiliation don’t matter # Age doesn’t matter # Life begins at eighty # Hey, you can do it too.

Every line was outrageous!

Simply reading those magnificent words was enough to set blood surging and hearts pounding. Shouts erupted from the crowd.

“Yeah! I can do it too!”

“You too? Me too!”

“Aaaah! The Two Dragons Pavilion is calling me!”

“Damn it! The level of injuring others with Sword Energy!”

Hundreds of people who had read the notice were cheering or groaning when—

Ting-a-ling.

A clear, lively melody rang out from somewhere.

The crowd parted as though by prior agreement. A group appeared and passed through them, walking as if on clouds.

“What’s that…?”

“Isn’t that the band from Honghakru?”

“Why would a band show up here?”

It was one of the ten most famous bands in Henan, and its sudden arrival left everyone bewildered.

Then a breathtakingly beautiful woman appeared before the crowd and smiled.

“Hongmae? It’s Hongmae!”

“Waaaaah!”

Hongmae was Honghakru’s most beautiful singer, a singing courtesan famous for her enchanting voice. She bowed her head with graceful poise, then gave a meaningful glance. The musicians took their cue and began to play.

Ting-a-ling. Chaarang!

The melody was bright and lively.

And the moment the first line flowed from her lips, the martial artists there understood as if under a spell.

“Join the Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion, and my era of success begins~”

“…!”

If they wanted to succeed, they had to join the Two Dragons Pavilion.

I’d always been this way. No particular reason—I’d just never liked songs or children all that much.

But today was an exception.

“Heh heh. Those little rascals.”

I smiled contentedly as I listened to the sounds coming through the gap in the window.

Outside, children who looked to be around elementary school age were running around energetically and singing.

“Join the Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion, and my era of success begins~!”

“Join the Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion, and now more sects are looking for me~!”

“Join the Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion, and my life has changed~!”

“A new era, a new hero!”

“The Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion!”

The ending was perfect, too.

I gave myself a little round of applause, then noticed Hyuk Mujin staring at me in disbelief.

"What is it, you bastard?"

"…I'm just stunned. I've never seen or heard of anything like this."

"What do you think? Innovative, isn't it?"

Hyuk Mujin nodded reluctantly.

"It definitely works. I just went around checking, and it's chaos out there. You'd think Dark Heaven had invaded."

"I knew it would work. Heh heh."

"That song in particular… It's everywhere. People are saying you've released poison into Murim, Captain."

"What's that supposed to mean? What poison?"

"They say it's more addictive than opium."

"Oh. Ohoho."

Ah, how satisfying.

What a rewarding outcome. A certain cyber university in Seoul might sue me for plagiarism, but this was Murim. (Audio reference)

I'm sorry, and thank you. I'll put the song to good use.

And so the greatest hit of the era was born, destined to mercilessly assault the eardrums of these primitive Murim bumpkins.

I still got a thrill remembering the bandleader's and singer's faces when I'd given them the melody I'd hastily come up with.

They looked like primitive humans discovering fire.

Was this how Prometheus had felt in Greek mythology?

The difference was that, instead of donating my organs to an eagle sent by Zeus, I had to deal with the flood of applicants.

"How is the application process? Are you done?"

Hyuk Mujin looked at me as though I'd lost my mind.

"Are you serious?"

"More than I expected, huh?"

"It's insane. Completely insane. There are so many, I'm starting to wonder if Dark Heaven sent in applications too."

Hmm. It seemed to be even more effective than I'd imagined.

I'd added the requirement of being a Peak master in case something like this happened, but the world was vast, and apparently it had plenty of masters.

"Then let's do this. First…"

I'd just finished thinking it over and begun to speak when—

Crash!

The door broke apart, and someone appeared.

“Join the Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion. My era of success begins.”

The most ominous song in the world. A chilling expression.

I froze when I met those glowing red eyes. Fire King Jeok Cheongang spat out his next words.

“This old man nearly suffered qi deviation because of that damn song.”

“…Welcome.”

Chapter 541

Henan was a land with a long and storied history.

It was home to sprawling thousand-year-old capitals such as Kaifeng and Luoyang, cities that had served as the seats of numerous dynasties. It also offered breathtaking natural scenery and all sorts of famous landmarks, including four great mountains.

Visitors came year-round. Naturally, there were plenty of inns, pleasure houses, and other places for entertainment and lodging.

But the old innkeeper, whose family had run the same inn for three generations, could confidently say this street had never been so crowded.

What in the world…?

He stared around in bewilderment at a veritable sea of people.

“Hey, wait a minute! Don’t try to cut in line!”

“Who keeps shoving me?”

“You little pup. You’ve been giving me insolent looks for a while now. Do I have to show you a coffin before you come to your senses?”

“What did you say? I was willing to let it go, but this lowly wandering martial artist is—”

“Heh heh. Everyone’s certainly full of energy. It’s a pleasant sight.”

“Pleasant? It’s been so noisy that I can hardly stand it.”

A wandering martial artist who looked like a wild wolf and a man who appeared to be the scion of a prestigious family glared at each other.

The sight made a half-gray-haired middle-aged man burst into hearty laughter, while a beautiful woman whose age was impossible to guess clicked her tongue.

Countless others stood farther away, watching and whispering among themselves.

What on earth is going on here?

In the middle of the chaos, just as the innkeeper felt his soul halfway leaving his body, a voice reached his ears.

“There’s no need to worry so much.”

“Pardon?”

“Not over there. This way.”

The innkeeper turned again in surprise. An old man sat at a table, leisurely sipping from a wine cup while everyone else waited in line.

“They have their own reasons for being here. There won’t be any serious trouble.”

He was small, with an unruly white beard and a face flushed red with drink.

For a moment, the innkeeper wondered if he might be a martial artist. But he looked for all the world like an ordinary old drunk. The innkeeper gave him a discreet glance, then lowered his voice.

“W-What in the world is going on?”

“They’re all people who want to begin their era of success. You must have heard that song, too. ‘Join the Murim Alliance’s Two Dragons Pavilion, and—‘”

The old man began humming a lively tune.

The innkeeper’s shoulders instinctively began to sway. Then his eyes widened.

“Ah. Are you talking about that… Two Dragons Pavilion?”

“You got it. The young Pavilion Master of that Two Dragons Pavilion is staying right here.”

“Good heavens.”

The innkeeper let out a short gasp.

He had known that the person staying in the detached building was a young knight-errant famous throughout the martial world. But he had never imagined that he was the Pavilion Master of the Two Dragons Pavilion everyone was talking about.

“So that’s why so many martial artists have come here. But even so, I never imagined there would be this many…”

“Heh heh. Isn’t it a fine opportunity? It’s rare to find a place that doesn’t care about your background, gender, or age.”

“That’s true. I heard even an eighty-year-old can apply.”

The old man answered quietly.

“As it happens, that’s exactly what I intend to do.”

“Hahaha! You certainly know how to make a joke.”

“Does that sound like a joke?”

“Pardon?”

“I asked whether that sounded like a joke.”

The innkeeper’s laughter stopped. He stared at the old man, his eyes trembling.

“Th-Then, old man—I mean, sir—you’re applying too?”

“Isn’t that obvious?”

The old man wiped his wine-soaked beard with his sleeve. As his robe shifted, a worn scabbard showed beneath it.

“I’m a martial artist too. Like them. Unlike you.”

“Gasp.”

“There’s no need to be so frightened. This old man doesn’t lay a hand on commoners.”

He paused to consider something, then added softly, “Most of the time.”

“…!”

Not a trace of drunkenness remained in his gentle voice, and for an instant, his eyes held the ferocity of a wild beast.

The innkeeper felt a chill and took an involuntary step back. Just then, someone began coming down the stairs.

Step. Step.

The old man's eyes flashed.

"Is it about to begin?"

He was not the only one who thought so. The dozens of Peak masters waiting in line and the spectators who seemed to outnumber them ten to one all fell silent.

Someone appeared on the stairs.

"How many people have come—whoa! You startled me."

The young man, Hyuk Mujin, jumped in surprise. A flicker of disappointment crossed the faces of those watching.

But the Peak masters, who had sensed his aura long before he appeared, merely muttered calmly.

"He's not the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon."

"He sent a messenger down in his place. Is he already throwing his weight around?"

"He's impressive for a messenger. With that kind of aura at his age, he's better than most second-generation Disciples from prestigious sects."

"I agree. And if it's the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, I suppose he can send someone in his place."

Hyuk Mujin looked sourly at the enormous crowd murmuring around him and cleared his throat.

"Ahem. The Captain—I mean, the Pavilion Master—has ordered me to begin the interviews. I'll call you by name, one at a time. Please follow me when your turn comes."

Reaching the Peak realm meant being recognized as a master anywhere in Murim. The Peak masters all took pride in their abilities, and they were plainly unhappy to be told to wait again. But none complained.

A thirsty man had to dig his own well. Having come here, they had to put up with it.

"I understand perfectly well, so stop spouting nonsense and call the names already."

Hyuk Mujin's eyes widened at the rough-looking middle-aged wandering martial artist.

"Oh. It's true."

"What is?"

"Ah, it's nothing. The Pavilion Master told me to reject anyone who uses informal speech and acts rudely the first time they meet someone, no exceptions. I didn't expect to find someone so quickly."

"…What?"

"Let's see. You're Great Hero No Guisan, the Black Blood Saber, correct? You may go home now."

The Black Blood Saber blinked at him in silence, then roared.

"What kind of bullshit rule is that?"

Hyuk Mujin pulled a bamboo slip bearing the man's personal details from the purse at his waist and nodded.

"It's right here. That kind of rule."

"I waited an entire shichen[2521]!"

"Oh dear. That's unfortunate."

"You insolent little bastard! You think you can act this arrogantly because your master's behind you? Do you really think you'll be safe after this?"

"I think I'll probably be fine."

"You little—!"

"If you keep this up, our Pavilion Master will come down himself and say, 'You bastard!'"

What kind of person was this?

The Black Blood Saber and everyone watching stood with their mouths open.

The Black Blood Saber was a formidable fighter, renowned even among the rough-and-tumble wandering martial artists. People said that if not for his foul temper, he could become the Sect Leader of a school that very day and build it into a mid-level sect.

Yet Hyuk Mujin did not so much as blink before the aura he released.

"You're rejected. Off you go."

For Hyuk Mujin, who had followed Jin Taekyung around and suffered every kind of hell, his composure was only natural. It left even the foul-tempered Black Blood Saber speechless.

That was when—

"Ha! Hahaha!"

Rumble!

A booming laugh erupted from somewhere. The air burst outward, and the ground trembled in tiny shudders.

The Peak masters went rigid as they sensed the source of the overwhelming aura pressing down on them.

What incredible internal energy…!

One level above me. No—two levels.

What in the world…?

[2521] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Every horrified gaze turned toward the old man who had been leisurely sipping his wine moments earlier. He was slowly rising from his seat.

“Don’t make such a commotion. Don’t you feel sorry for the innkeeper?”

He smiled gently at the innkeeper, who lay facedown and trembling. Someone in the crowd cried out, almost screaming.

“O-Old Man Ilyang!”

Old Man Ilyang. Those three words were enough.

He was a master who stood between the orthodox and unorthodox paths and had once dominated an era. His was the sobriquet of a monster who had burned countless opponents to death with his mighty Scorching Yang Qi.

The sudden appearance of a Supreme Peak master froze the entire gathering.

Is that truly Old Man Ilyang?

Th-That old monster… What is he doing here?

No one present could compare to him. It was doubtful they could bring him down even if they all attacked together.

Only one wall separated Peak from Supreme Peak. The distance across it was vast.

Step. Step.

Old Man Ilyang walked leisurely through the silence, then looked at Hyuk Mujin and smiled.

“Go and tell him this old man wishes to meet him.”

“…!”

Another ripple of shock passed through the crowd.

Old Man Ilyang, of all people, wanted to join the Two Dragons Pavilion under a Pavilion Master barely more than a boy. That alone was astonishing. Yet he had made his request so courteously.

“U-Understood. Please wait a moment.”

Hyuk Mujin turned away, flustered. He did not see the ominous heat in Old Man Ilyang’s eyes.

The Fire Gate Clan. The Fire Gate Clan, huh? Heh heh. At long last, an opportunity has come even to this old man.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung? Whether the rumors about him were true did not matter.

He was still a brat barely past twenty. At Old Man Ilyang’s age, he had no intention whatsoever of respectfully serving such a fledgling as his superior. But…

The Fire Gate Clan’s divine technique, passed down to only one person each generation. I will make it mine, whatever it takes.

He had spent his life pursuing strength, yet had never reached the pinnacle of Scorching Yang Qi.

With the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts, he could. He could even claim the title of greatest under heaven.

According to reliable rumors, Fire King Jeok Cheongang won't be joining the Two Dragons Pavilion. That leaves only his young Disciple and the other riffraff.

The moment the Two Dragons Pavilion received a mission and left Henan would be his chance.

Dark Heaven? The Murim Alliance? What did he care what became of Murim's fate?

The corner of his mouth, covered in age spots, twitched.

"Heh heh. Hahaha."

Before Old Man Ilyang's eyes, the five characters for *greatest under heaven* were already shimmering.

Eighty-five years old.

Name: Won Cheol.

Sobriquet: Old Man Ilyang.

His martial arts realm was Supreme Peak.

It was a practically perfect profile, without a single thing to criticize.

But the special judge he had suddenly found himself facing had a different opinion.

"He's got the eyes of a bastard who'd stab you in the back the first chance he got."

"Pardon?"

There was no need to ask what he meant. Jeok Cheongang had already closed the distance and was smashing his fist into Old Man Ilyang's mouth.

Whoosh!

Extreme Yang energy surged from the blow, enough to turn anything in its path to ash.

Old Man Ilyang sucked in a sharp breath and hurriedly crossed his arms to block it, but the difference in strength was obvious.

That's bad.

Even Scorching Yang Qi had its levels. If Old Man Ilyang's qi was an ordinary flame, Fire King Jeok Cheongang's was lava.

That difference became clear in an instant.

Crunch. Wham!

Bones shattered, and Old Man Ilyang's eyes lost focus.

I watched with genuine regret and shouted, "No! The ace—!"

But once Jeok Cheongang's fist began spitting fire, it did not stop.

Wham! Wham! Wham-wham-wham!

Arms, legs, stomach, back, face.

As if to show off his regained youth, he drove qi-packed punches into every part of Old Man Ilyang's body. With each blow, tangible Scorching Yang Qi enveloped the area.

Wow. I'm seeing the pit of fire right here.

Was this audition genre hip-hop?

One Sun[2522]—no, Old Man Ilyang, who had not even received a necklace, lost consciousness without managing a single proper counterattack.

Thud.

Old Man Ilyang collapsed like crumbling ash. Jeok Cheongang stood looking down at him, then muttered, "Now I remember this bastard. He's the son of a bitch who said he was after our sect's martial arts."

"…I'm glad you had a reason, at least. I thought you'd gone mad, Old Master."

"Better late than never. I can't stand the sight of him, so get him out of here."

Not long after Old Man Ilyang's corpse—or rather, his body—was carried away, a commotion broke out outside.

I glanced through the window. Terrified applicants were fleeing, even using their movement techniques to get away.

"…Oh, for fuck's sake."

Do they have any idea what it took to arrange this? The audition was completely fucked. Seriously.

Jeok Cheongang caught my resentful look and answered bluntly.

"What do you want me to do?"

"You could've gone a little easier on him. Wanting to get his hands on some martial arts isn't a capital crime. He hadn't actually done anything yet. You could've just rejected him quietly."

"Tsk, tsk. What an innocent fool. People like that always cause trouble eventually. You have to stamp out a spark before it becomes a fire."

"…Don't people usually say you should uproot weeds?"

"You can leave weeds alone. A spark can burn down a mountain."

I mean, what was he, the chairman of a forest conservation society?

I was muttering inwardly in disbelief when Jeok Cheongang continued.

"And…"

"What now?"

He jerked his chin toward the window.

"When someone leaves, someone else comes."

[2522] One Sun is a Korean rapper associated with hip-hop audition shows, where contestants who pass an initial round receive a necklace.

“Huh?”

Chapter 542

You could tell a lot about a person from the way they walked.

That was especially true of martial artists. Their footsteps revealed more than most people would think.

Someone who relied on brute strength in their martial arts tended to walk heavily and roughly. Someone who practiced a more graceful art—or worked as an assassin—might move so lightly you could barely hear them.

Whoever was coming up the stairs now wasn't just announcing his presence. His footsteps were practically screaming it.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

Listen to that.

The noise was heavy enough to make an ordinary person's heart sink. With every step, the solidly built staircase creaked and a faint tremor ran through the floor.

Jeok Cheongang had already taken the gourd from his side and begun sipping from it. He spoke with a grave expression.

"Dark Heaven. Now they're turning people into monsters. What sort of trick did they use?"

"Huh?"

For a moment, I had no idea what he meant. Then I understood and waved a hand.

"Sorry to interrupt, but the guy coming up isn't from Dark Heaven."

"Hmm. He's no one to worry about, regardless. Knock him down as soon as he opens the door and comes in. Hand him over to the Murim Alliance, and we may get something useful out of him."

"…He's not from Dark Heaven. And you already smashed the door, Old Master. What door are you talking about?"

"What?"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes went wide as he spoke, spraying spit.

"You mean that fellow coming up is a pure human?"

"Amazingly, he's all-natural."

"Well, you do see some things if you live long enough. The qi I sense from him isn't particularly pure, though."

Hyuk Mujin had returned after taking the injured man downstairs. Wiping his palm, still slick with Old Man Ilyang's blood, on his trouser leg, he answered.

"Ah, as expected of Great Hero Jeok. You recognized demonic, heterodox arts at once."

"Demonic, heterodox arts?"

"Yes. The Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate and his subordinate."

The thundering footsteps had drowned out the other sound, but there had been two people coming up from the start.

At last, they appeared through the doorway Jeok Cheongang had blown wide open.

“This junior of Murim, Sama Pyo, pays his respects to Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King.”

Tall and handsome. The moment I saw him, my mouth felt as gritty as if I’d bitten into sand.

Two words had flashed through my mind.

Former fiancé.

Whether he knew what I was thinking or not, Sama Pyo clasped his hands in greeting to Jeok Cheongang, then nudged the hulking figure standing blankly beside him.

“What are you doing? Pay your respects.”

Tiger Giant Child Taishan, whose name and epithet fit him perfectly, bent at the waist.

“Nice to meet. Taishan saw Fire King.”

“…”

That was a new one.

I stole a glance at Jeok Cheongang. He looked ready to introduce Taishan to Yama[2523] instead of the Fire King.

Sama Pyo seemed to notice and quickly explained.

“As you may have guessed, his vocabulary is limited. That’s the best he can do.”

“…In that case, I suppose it can’t be helped.”

Jeok Cheongang muttered, looking less than pleased.

“I’ve seen some strange fellows in my time. Fine. This old man has seen you too.”

“Heh heh.”

Taishan smiled innocently and gave him two thumbs up.

“Fire King. Strong. Taishan likes strong people. Nice to meet.”

“Y-Yes. This old man is pleased to meet you too.”

“But Taishan. Hungry.”

“W-What?”

“Want to eat that. If Fire King says yes, Taishan grateful.”

His hungry eyes had already moved past our shoulders.

Jeok Cheongang spotted the refreshments on the table and nodded before he quite knew what he was doing.

“G-Go ahead.”

“Wow! Refreshments! Taishan thanks you for the food!”

[2523] Yama is the ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

Thud! Crack!

The innkeeper was going to weep tears of blood.

The enormous man charged forward, smashing what remained of the door on his way in. As though he'd been waiting for permission, Taishan swept up everything on the table. Jeok Cheongang watched him in a daze.

"Have I lived too long?"

Even Jeok Cheongang couldn't help being taken aback.

Then again, he was used to people cowering the moment they heard the words *Fire King*. Aside from Cheongpung, this might be the first formidable opponent he'd encountered.

Anyway.

I scratched the back of my head and looked Sama Pyo up and down.

"So. What brings you here?"

"I have important business. If it's all right with you, I'd rather discuss it inside."

"It's not all right with me."

Sama Pyo shrugged.

"I asked out of courtesy, but you really aren't ordinary. Do you also harbor ill feelings toward the demonic, heterodox path?"

"It's not that, exactly…"

Damn it. Put that way, I didn't have much of an answer.

I had only met him once, but my first impression of him had not been particularly bad. Nor was I some hardcore zealot who shouted about eradicating the heterodox path and glorifying the orthodox faction whenever I got the chance.

Jeok Cheongang didn't seem to feel much differently.

"What are you two doing standing there? Falling for each other?"

With Jeok Cheongang saying that, I had no good reason to keep Sama Pyo out. I jerked my chin toward him.

"Damn it. Come in, then."

"Thank you. And thank you, Great Hero Jeok."

Sama Pyo entered with a polite bow. Jeok Cheongang nodded.

"The young brat has some manners. Or did he inherit his father's sly streak?"

Sama Pyo paused, then smiled.

"Probably the latter. So you remember my father."

"I'd forgotten him until I saw your face. You're the spitting image of the Black Night King in his younger days."

Black Night King Sima Gong.

Sama Pyo's father, and the man who had built the Black Dragon Demon Gate into what it was today.

His epithet made him sound like one of the Ten Kings, but according to Gung Gibang, he had nothing to do with them.

Just like the Green Forest Battle King, the Green Forest Alliance Leader, and the Escort King of the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

They were Supreme Peak masters whose martial prowess was beyond most people's reach. That still wasn't enough to make them part of the legend of the Ten Kings.

Black Night King Sima Gong, one of the greatest masters in the unorthodox martial world and the Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, had apparently received the title in much the same way.

"Still…"

Jeok Cheongang studied Sama Pyo, then frowned.

"I didn't know the Black Night King had a son so young."

"I have seven older brothers and nine older sisters. I'm the youngest."

"Hah. The Virility Saber King would weep if he heard that. So you're the Young Sect Leader."

Sama Pyo's eyes widened slightly.

"I am, but how did you—"

"Isn't it obvious?"

Jeok Cheongang snorted.

"Given the Black Night King's personality, that is exactly what he would do. If your talent was sufficient, he wouldn't care even if it meant burying all his other children alive as sacrifices."

"…"

"He hasn't changed much, then. You could never tell what that man was thinking. Sly as a fox and cunning as a viper."

Look at him, casually throwing a parent insult right to his face. My heart almost swelled with awe.

The insult implied he recognized Sama Pyo's talent, but it was still an insult. Before the dutiful son could take offense and start something, I cut in.

"So what brings you here?"

"…Hmm. Well."

Sama Pyo's expression was hard to read. He reached inside his robe and took something out.

Paper—a fairly expensive commodity in Murim. The words at the top caught my eye at once.

I stared at the sheet he'd laid on the table and rubbed my chin.

"This looks familiar."

Sama Pyo gave a quiet laugh.

"It would."

"I don't know who came up with it, but they're a genius."

"It's rather bold, too."

Tap.

Sama Pyo's long finger came down on one part of the sheet: the recruitment requirements Hyuk Mujin had scrawled in his terrible handwriting. Of all the lines beneath them, he pointed to one in particular.

> # Gender and sect affiliation don't matter

His soft voice continued.

"I especially like this part."

"So?"

"I'd like to apply. To the Two Dragons Pavilion."

I'd suspected as much, but hearing him say it still left me with mixed feelings.

I thought for a moment, then clicked my tongue.

"Why?"

"The moment I heard the song, I had a feeling. This is exactly the place I've been looking for."

"Yeah. Bullshit."

That wasn't even funny.

The song promised a new era of success, more sects seeking you out, and a changed life. None of that applied to Sama Pyo.

The Black Dragon Demon Gate was one of the three most powerful sects in the unorthodox martial world. Even if Sama Pyo hadn't been its Young Sect Leader, being born the Black Night King's son all but guaranteed him wealth and status.

And he wants to join the Two Dragons Pavilion?

Even if the orthodox faction's diehards held up picket signs and protested, Sama Pyo was more than capable of securing a position within the Murim Alliance.

I folded my arms and stared at him.

"If this is a joke, it's not funny."

"Fortunately, I'm serious."

"Cut the bullshit. What's the real reason?"

"The notice didn't say I had to give one."

"Then get lost. I won't see you out."

Sama Pyo shrugged as though he had no choice.

“I thought that if I joined the Two Dragons Pavilion, I might be able to shed the label of belonging to the demonic, heterodox path.”

“You don’t seem all that eager to shed it.”

“Is that really how I seem?”

“I don’t trust you.”

“Fair enough. Then I’ll speak frankly.”

“Go on. Unless you want the shit beaten out of you.”

Sama Pyo gave a quiet laugh. Then his expression hardened.

A low voice slipped from between his perfectly smooth lips and pierced my ears.

“I intend to use you for my own benefit. Depending on the circumstances, you will become a useful card to me in one way or another.”

A heavy silence fell.

Even Taishan, who had been chewing noisily without pause, stopped moving. Hyuk Mujin stared back and forth between Sama Pyo and me with eyes as wide as lanterns.

Then someone broke the silence.

“What an interesting fellow.”

Jeok Cheongang was watching Sama Pyo with an expression I couldn’t read. Was he amused or angry? He turned to me.

“What do you think?”

I considered it for a moment.

“He makes quite an impression. I doubt this is his first interview.”

“Will you take him?”

“Hard to say.”

Black Dragon Saber Sama Pyo. I couldn’t tell how much of what he’d said was a joke and how much he meant.

But one thing was certain.

He’s interesting.

Tap. Tap.

The only sound echoing through the silence was the tapping of fingers against the table.

I gathered my thoughts in that brief silence and looked Sama Pyo straight in the eye.

“Let’s make one thing clear first.”

“By all means.”

“If you try anything—”

“Summary execution,” Sama Pyo said before I could finish. “I’ll remember.”

“Huh. Straight to the point.”

“It’s only natural. Are we done, then?”

“You haven’t been accepted yet. I’m only keeping you under consideration for now. For today, go.”

“Very well.”

What in the world was this man after?

I watched Sama Pyo and Taishan prepare to leave, my curiosity only growing. Then I remembered one important thing.

“And one more thing.”

“…?”

“You’re paying for that guy’s food.”

“…!”

Chapter 543

Thud. Thud.

Footsteps shook the ground, and people on the street moved aside to clear a path.

Black Dragon Saber Sama Pyo knew the wary looks were not because of Taishan walking beside him.

The rumors about us have spread, then.

It would have been stranger if they hadn't.

A grimy yellow knot protruded from the belt of a beggar dozing against an alley wall. Faint calluses marked the palm of a stallkeeper swatting at flies.

The Beggars' Sect. The Lower District Sect.

And those were only the ones he could spot at a glance.

Countless eyes watched him wherever he went in Henan. Before half a day had passed, word of what he had done today would reach any number of people.

Not that I intended to hide it.

Trying to conceal his movements would only invite greater suspicion. Sama Pyo had no intention of ruining things through half-baked caution.

—My lord.

Taishan's cautious Sound Transmission reached his ear. Without showing any reaction, Sama Pyo pointed to a small noodle shop off to one side.

"I'm in the mood for thin noodles today. Shall we stop for a bowl?"

"Hm?"

"You must be full. Say so if you don't want any."

"No! Taishan likes noodles!"

"You should have said so. Excuse me. Ten bowls of thin noodles… No, make that twenty."

The middle-aged woman running the shop looked as though she doubted her ears.

"…How many bowls did you say?"

Sama Pyo had chosen the noodle shop for a simple reason. Perhaps because of its poor location, it had no other customers. They could sit with their backs to the street and exchange Sound Transmissions out of everyone else's sight.

It also helped that the owner appeared to be an ordinary commoner with no connection to Murim.

"Twenty bowls. As you can see, I have a hungry ghost with me."

"Y-Yes!"

It must have been an unexpected windfall for her. As her eyes lit up and she hurried to work, Sama Pyo barely moved his lips.

—You had something to say.

The small chair creaked under Taishan's weight. Balanced precariously on it, he answered.

—My lord. Taishan worried.

—About what?

—Did not obey Sect Leader's orders. Taishan worried about my lord.

A bitter smile touched Sama Pyo's lips.

—I wondered if that might be the reason. So it was because of that person after all.

—Disobeying bad. Sect Leader gets angry. My lord in danger.

—Yes. He is more than capable of that.

Sama Pyo looked down at the chopsticks neatly arranged on the table.

They brought to mind his father, Black Night King Sima Gong. A man with no paternal affection whatsoever.

He probably thinks of his children as chopsticks.

Replace one when it falls on the ground. Put it away when it no longer pleases him.

His seven older brothers and nine older sisters had been discarded that way. Sama Pyo was the last—and best-made—chopstick the Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate had chosen.

And even I might be replaced someday.

His father was well past eighty, but his appetite and libido were as vigorous as ever. Three wives and four concubines had not been enough for him; he had taken more than ten concubines in all. Sama Pyo had no shortage of blood relatives, older or younger.

But—

—Don't worry.

—Hm?

Sama Pyo took a sip of the lukewarm water the owner had brought him.

—He is heartless. That is precisely why he cannot easily cast me aside.

Black Night King Sima Gong was indeed a heartless man. He could set aside parental affection and assess reality with a cold eye.

By the same logic, there was no other successor who could replace Sama Pyo, whose martial talent surpassed even Sima Gong's in his younger days and whose calculating mind ran deep.

Besides…

—There will be no punishment. I've taken a different route, but it still leads where my father wants to go.

—My lord. Taishan does not understand. Taishan is stupid.

Sama Pyo smiled at Taishan, who could only tilt his head in confusion.

—You don't need to understand. Just stay by my side. All right?

—Taishan listens to my lord. Taishan is good.

Taishan nodded vigorously. Just then, the owner began setting bowls piled high with thin noodles on the table.

“Careful, they’re hot. Take your time—”

“Wow! Taishan! Thank you for the food!”

“Oh my goodness!”

The owner stared in shock as Taishan lifted a bowl of steaming noodles and gulped them down.

Sama Pyo let out a quiet laugh at the sight. Then his face went rigid.

“Hmm.”

Taishan looked up from his noodles.

“My lord. What is it?”

“…”

“My lord?”

Still staring at something, Sama Pyo murmured, “No. Nothing. I must have seen wrong.”

But he knew he had not mistaken the person who had passed by. He knew what that person’s presence meant, too.

“…Perhaps I should have just obeyed the order.”

“Hm? My lord. What did you say?”

Sama Pyo answered with a sigh. Taishan already had the last bowl in his hands.

“You shameless glutton. Finish stuffing your face.”

“Wow! Taishan will give his life for my lord!”

“Here you go.”

A voice clearer and lovelier than a Young Chang piano.[2524] A hand held out two bamboo slips to me.

What’s going on?

Less than half an hour had passed since the two uninvited guests from the Black Dragon Demon Gate had left and Jeok Cheongang had gone to the latrine. Now another unexpected visitor had appeared, and this one left me at a loss.

I blinked at her, then finally managed to speak.

“W-What are these?”

“Applications.”

Ju Hwaran looked as though she wondered why I had to ask. “One for me and one for Captain Song.”

Behind her, Song Ilseom muttered, “I never agreed to this.”

[2524] Young Chang is a Korean piano manufacturer.

“I hired you, didn’t I? If you’re my escort, of course you have to come with me.”

“This wasn’t in the contract. It’s a breach of contract. If I join the Murim Alliance, I’ll need hazard pay…”

“I’ll pay you double.”

“Then that’s a different story.”

Maybe it was all the money she had wrung out of the Zhongnan Sect. Ju Hwaran was showing off the sort of easy spending only someone young and rich could manage.

Watching her, though, I felt as stifled as if I’d stepped into a greenhouse in midsummer.

“So. You’re serious?”

“Yes. I am.”

Ju Hwaran nodded without hesitation and met my eyes.

“I want to join the Two Dragons Pavilion.”

“…!”

I had suspected as much, but hearing Ju Hwaran say it herself left my mouth dry. I thought for a moment before speaking.

“I won’t accept you just because we know each other.”

“If I’d planned to rely on our connection from the start, I would’ve come without an application, wouldn’t I?”

She smiled. I sighed inwardly.

“It’ll be dangerous. Very dangerous.”

“I know. The Two Dragons Pavilion is directly under the Alliance Leader’s Office, and unlike the other pavilions, it cannot even command its own squads or battalions. It will probably function more like a special operations detachment.”

Exactly right.

Mae Jonghak wanted to deploy Cheongpung and me, two considerable assets even within the Murim Alliance, as a small detached force. It was also why most of the leadership had agreed to the arrangement.

“Young Lady Ju, if you know that, why—”

“Great Hero Jin.”

Ju Hwaran cut me off.

“Did you say that to the other applicants?”

“What?”

“That it’s dangerous. Did you ask why they were applying when they knew that?”

Her quiet voice went on.

“It’s strange. You put up a notice because you needed people, and now you’re trying to talk me out of it.”

“That’s…”

She gave a quiet laugh when I hesitated.

“You don’t have an answer, do you?”

She had me there. I scratched the back of my head and reluctantly nodded.

“Honestly? No, I don’t.”

“I came here as a martial artist. I’d like you to judge me as one.”

“As you are…”

“I might fall far short by your standards, but I’m a swordswoman who has reached the Peak realm.”

“Since we’re being honest, you do fall pretty far short. Song Ilseom might be another story.”

Poke.

Hyuk Mujin, who had been watching with bated breath, gave me a discreet jab in the ribs.

He needn’t have worried. Ju Hwaran’s gaze did not waver.

“Even compared with the other applicants?”

“I can’t say for certain, but probably.”

“What about experience?”

“Experience?”

“I started accompanying my father on escort runs when I was twelve. In experience and knowledge of the land, I don’t think I fall short of any seasoned veteran of the martial world.”

She had a point. Ju Hwaran had been heir to the Yongbong Escort Bureau, once among the most renowned escort bureaus in the world. For the past several years, she had even run it herself after her father collapsed from qi deviation.

I can’t dismiss the experience she gained from that.

Escort bureaus traveled far and wide. To complete their assignments on time, they used whatever means they could, learning the roads and gathering information wherever they went.

And during the Great Faction War, Ju Hwaran’s grandfather, the Escort King, had completed his legendary Ten-Thousand-Li Journey[2525] while evading the Demonic Cult’s countless watchers.

“Great Hero Jin.”

Her powerful voice pierced my ears.

“I have no intention of becoming a burden. But please think about this objectively. Set aside everything that’s happened between us until now. Are Captain Song and I truly of no use to the Two Dragons Pavilion?”

“…!”

[2525] This uses the Chinese *li*, approximately 500 m (0.311 mi). Ten thousand *li* is approximately 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

"I'm fully prepared for what this entails. Even if you reject me, I'll accept it."

I closed my eyes.

Ju Hwaran was right. This was something I had to consider coldly.

The person waiting for my answer was not the woman I had walked beside one night in a garden where the flowers were just beginning to bloom.

Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran.

She was a martial artist skilled enough to be counted among the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, and the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

She also had abilities we would need on the missions ahead, given that the Two Dragons Pavilion would operate as a detached force.

Then why?

Why did I hate admitting it? Why did I want to stop her, even if I had to be unreasonable?

"Um, Captain."

I opened my eyes. Hyuk Mujin watched me nervously before going on.

"I think you've forgotten something."

"What?"

"All the other applicants ran away. Every last one. They probably won't come back tomorrow or the day after, either."

"I know, you punk. Old Man Ilyang got carried out of here half-paralyzed. So?"

"No, I mean… that's all I wanted to say."

Hyuk Mujin flinched and turned his head away.

But I understood him perfectly.

"Whew."

I sighed and looked straight at Ju Hwaran.

"Before I answer, there's one thing you should know, Young Lady Ju."

How was I supposed to bring it up? As I hesitated, she smiled.

"It doesn't matter."

"What?"

"I saw them on my way here. With someone that big beside him, how could I miss them? And from what people were whispering, I could more or less tell where they'd come from."

Ju Hwaran continued calmly.

"Why would that be a problem?"

"…!"

"I think I've given you enough time to consider it. May I have your answer?"

I studied her. The tangle in my head seemed to have cleared.

Or perhaps it hadn't, not entirely.

But right now, at least, I knew what I had to say.

“Yes. All right.”

A bright smile spread across Ju Hwaran’s face.

Chapter 544

Ju Hwaran had left.

Beyond the window, I watched her walk away, slender yet dignified, with Song Ilseom following like a shadow.

“Young Lady Ju is impressive,” Hyuk Mujin said behind me.

I nodded quietly.

She was like that back then, too.

I remembered the day I first met her: the way she had refused to retreat even when surrounded by hundreds of enemies, and the look in her eyes.

Maybe she’s more of a martial artist than I ever realized.

“I feel sorry for her, too,” Hyuk Mujin said.

“Yeah. She has a lot on her shoulders. Her father still has trouble getting around, and…”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“Hm?”

I turned to find him looking at me with pity.

“If all she wanted was to earn merit, she had plenty of other options. Why come all the way here?”

Why, huh?

I thought it over, then sucked in a breath.

“Wait. Don’t tell me…”

“Yes. Exactly.”

“Because she thought she could earn even more merit?”

“…That’s enough. This is too damn filthy to work with.”

I was debating whether to smack him when a voice came to his rescue.

“Ahh, what a relief.”

Jeok Cheongang emerged from the latrine after half an hour.

Apparently celebrating a smooth delivery, he was grinning from ear to ear as he reached for the liquor bottle first. Then he saw Hyuk Mujin’s expression and paused.

“Why do you look like you’ve been chewing shit?”

“Great Hero Jeok. The thing is…”

Hyuk Mujin launched into an explanation as though he had been waiting for someone to ask. Jeok Cheongang listened in silence, then widened his eyes.

“The Escort King’s granddaughter came here?”

“Yes.”

“Huh. Two people with unusual auras passed by while this old man was straining. She must have been one of them.”

Jeok Cheongang stroked his dark-red beard.

“I heard what happened while I was at death’s door. Now that things have come this far, it seems you share quite a lasting connection.”

“Then why do you think she came to Captain when she had other choices?”

The corner of Jeok Cheongang’s mouth twitched.

“Must this old man really say it aloud?”

“Right? I knew you’d understand, Great Hero Jeok.”

Hyuk Mujin’s face lit up like an LED bulb. Jeok Cheongang smiled knowingly and went on.

“Because she can earn a tremendous amount of merit.”

“…”

Oh. The bulb went out.

Hyuk Mujin’s face darkened like night had fallen. His voice dropped with it.

“Are you serious?”

Jeok Cheongang nodded confidently.

“She may have received considerable compensation from the Zhongnan Sect, but she’ll need fame and skill in Murim if she intends to protect and lead the Escort Bureau. The way I see it, the Escort King’s granddaughter understands how the world works.”

“Great Hero Jeok.”

“What?”

“Forgive me for asking, but have you ever had a sweetheart?”

Jeok Cheongang gave it some thought.

“Of course.”

“When?”

“I was about ten. More than a hundred years ago, I suppose.”

“…”

“What’s wrong?”

“N-Nothing. It seems I was practicing wall-facing meditation.”

“…?”

“A real wall. A wall. The Wailing Wall.”

Hyuk Mujin muttered like a monk who had attained enlightenment. Jeok Cheongang looked away from him and turned to me.

“Anyway, what do you intend to do?”

“Hmm.”

“Your face says you’ve already made up your mind. That’s why I’m asking.”

I shrugged.

“You’re psychic. I haven’t even told you yet.”

“From what I’ve heard, it’s not a bad choice. You’re a monster beyond reason, but reaching the Peak realm at her age is an impressive feat. And if she’s been involved in the Escort Bureau since childhood, she’ll have no shortage of experience.”

“I was thinking the same thing. The escort named Song Ilseom would be a major asset on skill alone.”

Jeok Cheongang had been at death’s door when the two of them were here, so he had never met them himself. But he had heard everything that happened after he woke, and had no trouble following the discussion.

“The last of the Guangdong Chen Family’s bloodline. From what I sensed in the latrine, he’s reached a considerable realm.”

“…That’s a little gross, but I agree.”

Jeok Cheongang was a Supreme Peak master who had reached the Returned to Youth[2526] realm. If he considered Song Ilseom’s skill considerable, then no one could dispute the man’s martial prowess.

Another genius the world never knew about.

Song Ilseom had lost his family young and been left alone in the world. He had wandered battlefields as a sword boy[2527] for wandering martial artists until, at last, he drew a sword of his own.

He wasn’t a flower raised in a greenhouse. He was a weed that had weathered the worst the world could throw at him.

His other name, Soul-Chasing Guest, was the stuff of legend even among wandering martial artists.

He’s no Cheongpung or Mungyeong, but he’d be a valuable addition.

It was a shame, but I had no complaints. The lineup around me had been unusually spectacular until now.

Things were bound to change.

A Supreme Peak master could reverse a losing battle in an instant. With the flames of war spreading in every direction, deploying them where they were needed was only natural.

Mae Jonghak must have separated Cheongpung and me for the same reason.

There were fires burning in several places. We could not keep sending the same fire truck to one location.

[2526] Returned to Youth is a martial-fiction concept in which attaining an advanced realm restores a person’s youthful appearance.

[2527] A sword boy was a young attendant hired by wandering martial artists to carry swords and perform errands, including dangerous ones.

If we wanted to win the war against Dark Heaven and prevent even more people from dying, this was the natural course.

And I needed to put together a team to fight those fires with me.

It was time to decide with a cool head.

I guess there's no helping it.

No matter how I looked at it, this was the best choice. Or if not the best, at least the next best.

I sorted out my thoughts and called a name quietly.

"Hyuk Mujin."

Hyuk Mujin could seem slow, but he was quick to read the room.

At the very least, he knew something was different whenever I called him by his full name.

"Yes, Captain."

"Let me ask you straight."

The choice wasn't mine alone. Each of us had to make our own, and together those choices would become one decision.

But before I could go on, Hyuk Mujin answered.

"I'll go with you."

"What?"

"I said I'll follow you, Captain. That's what you were going to ask, isn't it?"

"…Yeah."

"Then you didn't need to ask. The thread follows the needle. Of course, traitors like Gung don't count. That's the trouble with outsiders from other sects. They've always got some complication or other."

He gave me a playful smile. I stared at him for a moment, then smiled back.

"You won't regret it?"

"Regret?"

"Yeah. Regret."

"Captain. You know what?"

His expression turned serious.

"Ever since I met you, my life has been one long regret."

"You son of a bitch."

"But I figured a few more regrets wouldn't hurt."

He shrugged and spoke more slowly, gazing into the empty air as though searching through the past.

"A few years ago, people called me the son of the Hyuk Family Textile Shop. Then one day they started calling me the Swift Wind Sword. Some even call me the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon's right-hand man. I like that."

"Mujin, you…"

"Hehe. Touched?"

"No, that's not it. You're not my right-hand man. You're my little toe."

"Wow, Captain. After everything I've been through, I'm still just a little toe?"

His indignant face drew a quiet laugh out of me. Maybe it was time for a promotion.

"Fine. Little finger."

"…On your left hand?"

"Right."

"Right hand…"

He considered it, then cautiously made a counteroffer.

"I'll take the right hand. How about the thumb?"

"Try again in your next life."

"I knew you'd say that. Index finger, then?"

"Not a chance."

"Damn it. I'll have to devote my entire life to becoming your right-hand man. Does that make any sense?"

"Yeah, it'll take your whole life. So stay by my side until then. And don't die."

"…!"

Did I have to say that?

I hadn't been out of the bath long, but my skin felt strangely itchy. I scratched at my chin for no reason and held out my hand.

"C-Captain."

His eyes glistening, Hyuk Mujin firmly clasped it.

"Hyuk Mujin, your Captain's right little finger. I will devote my loyalty to—"

"What are you doing?"

"Huh?"

"Who asked for your hand? Bring me what you received earlier."

"…Oh."

Hyuk Mujin clicked his tongue, looking as if he should have known better, and pulled the two bamboo slips I'd handed him earlier from his robe.

Two names were written in tiny letters on the cords binding them.

Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran.

Soul-Chasing Guest Song Ilseom.

But these were not the only bamboo slips I needed to receive.

I kept my hand out. Hyuk Mujin seemed to guess what I meant, and his expression soured.

"Captain. Are you serious?"

"Yeah."

"Whew. I don't know if this is the right decision."

With a sigh, he added two more bamboo slips to my hand.

I looked down at the names and epithets on their cords.

Black Dragon Saber Sama Pyo.

Tiger Giant Child Taishan.

I don't know if this is the right decision.

Hyuk Mujin's words lingered. The reason was simple: I wasn't sure this was the best choice, either.

Then Jeok Cheongang spoke, and his words gave me the last bit of certainty I needed.

"What are you hesitating for? Just move forward."

My tangled thoughts cleared.

After taking a small, deep breath, I whispered toward some place deep within my heart.

Ju Hwaran, Song Ilseom, Sama Pyo, Taishan…

And last, Hyuk Mujin.

I sent all five names through my mind at once, then entered the command.

Approve Two Dragons Pavilion membership.

A voice answered the words no one else could hear.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Membership approval procedure initiated.

Confirmed: Dagger Hidden Flower Ju Hwaran, Soul-Chasing Guest Song Ilseom, Black Dragon Saber Sama Pyo, Tiger Giant Child Taishan, Swift Wind Sword Hyuk Mujin.

Will you accept the five people above as members of the Two Dragons Pavilion?

I already knew my answer.

I gave a small nod of acceptance. With a cheerful chime, the translucent holographic window floating in the air changed as though a page had been turned.

Ding.

SYSTEM

One condition of Quest Become My Companion! has been completed.
Secure at least five companions (Complete)
You have selected the minimum number of members!
One final procedure remains before you become an official Pavilion Master. Choose a new name for the Pavilion assigned to you!

A name, huh?

I hadn't given any thought to what I'd call the newly formed organization.

But no matter how much I thought about it, nothing could possibly be better than the name that had just flashed through my mind.

Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Clear bell tones burst out like celebratory fireworks, and resounding System alerts rang in my ears.

Chapter 545

Fire Dragon Pavilion.

The moment I murmured those three words—

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Clear bell tones burst like celebratory fireworks, and a new holographic window flooded my vision.

SYSTEM

- **Fire Dragon Pavilion has been registered as the new name!**
- **All Quest conditions have been fulfilled!**
- **Quest Become My Companion! has been successfully completed!**
- **Fire Dragon Pavilion has been officially established!**
- **You have acquired the unique Title Fire Dragon Pavilion Master!**
- **You have achieved the rare achievement Murim Alliance Civil Servant with a Sword Rice Bowl[2528]!**
- **You have acquired a large amount of Fame and EXP!**

A completed Quest, an achievement, and even the unique Title **Fire Dragon Pavilion Master**.

Notifications poured in all at once. But the System had more rewards in store.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

- **Even now, your name is echoing throughout Murim.**
- **Your total Fame has surpassed 10,000!**
- **You have achieved the outstanding achievement If You Don't Know Him, You Must Be Dark Heaven!**
- **As an achievement reward, some Title effects have been strengthened, and Charm and Intimidation have increased significantly!**
- **You have acquired a large amount of Fame and EXP!**
- **Level Up!**

Oh, shit.

[2528] *Kalbaptong* plays on making a living by the sword and *baptong*, a "rice bowl" or livelihood. The achievement pairs that image with a civil servant's post.

Was today Christmas or something?

I'd stopped paying much attention to Fame, but the huge amount I'd just gained had pushed my total past 10,000 and earned me an unexpected extra reward.

Some Title effects and stats had been strengthened. And on top of that…

I leveled up.

Even crappy online games made leveling harder the further you progressed, but lately it had become next to impossible. It was almost as if the System had forcibly nerfed me.

With so many battles ahead, every bonus point from a level-up was worth more than any fortune.

Come to think of it, I must have quite a few bonus points saved up. Titles, too.

Was the last time I checked my Status Window right after I defeated the Water God Dragon?

When I first came to Murim, I'd been so anxious that I opened it dozens of times a day. Gradually, I'd checked it less and less. These days, I hardly looked at it at all.

That was because, once my stats had reached a certain level, I had realized that they were little more than luck. What truly determined the outcome of a decisive moment was martial arts.

Still, I should sort everything out soon.

It felt like only yesterday that I had been called the disgrace of my family at Level 10. Now I was a monster who had sailed past Level 100, as well as a nationally famous Supreme Peak master whom no one in Murim failed to recognize.

I was smiling to myself at the thought of how far I'd come when Jeok Cheongang spoke in a disgruntled voice.

"You're grinning from ear to ear. Does becoming a Pavilion Master make you that happy?"

"Oh, that's not the only reason."

"Then what? Are you glad to be rid of this old man?"

"Huh?"

Only then did I understand why he looked so displeased. I stopped short.

"Are you sulking because of that?"

"Sulking? Me? The Fire King Jeok Cheongang?"

His eyes bulged, and he gave a mighty snort.

"Hah! What nonsense!"

"…Easy with the snorting. Your boogers are flying. And with a reaction like that, even a passing mutt could tell."

"You ill-mannered brat! What do you think you know?"

Well, that settles it.

I took a step back from Jeok Cheongang's flying spit and tried to calm him down.

"It can't be helped. It's not my fault you joined the Five Kings Hall."

The Five Kings Hall was an organization newly established by the new Murim Alliance, which had carried over the old Murim Alliance's structure.

It had only five members, but you could call it the strongest fighting force in the Murim Alliance—perhaps in all of Murim.

Just look at the lineup. It was practically Murim's Avengers.

Thunderbolt Saber King Peng Cheolhu. Azure Sky Sword King Namgung Cheon. Seafaring King Pa Ryun. Fist King Yan Hwapyeong. And…

The man standing right in front of me: Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

With members like that, they hadn't called it the Five Kings Hall for nothing. Five of the Ten Kings, men who had held their places through the long passage of years, had gathered there.

Living legends. Every one of them.

And Jeok Cheongang sat at their head.

By Murim's standards of seniority and age, he was old enough to have drunk skull water with Bodhidharma.[2529] As for the martial arts that had brought him to Returned to Youth, no one could dispute his mastery.

He was considered the best of the Ten Kings even during the Great Faction War.

When we encountered the Blood Lord during the Shaolin Bloodshed, that bastard had tried to recruit Jeok Cheongang from the outset rather than fight him. He'd even said that if the Great Faction War had lasted a little longer, Jeok Cheongang would have become one of the Four Saints instead of the Three Saints.

But…

"Five Kings Hall, my ass. They've stuck me with an office that wasn't even written in my stars."[2530]

The man himself wouldn't stop grumbling.

He held the highest seat in a hall of living legends, and he couldn't have been less pleased.

Hyuk Mujin, who had been watching him closely, raised a tentative hand.

"Um…"

"What?"

"If Great Hero Jeok leaves the Five Kings Hall, could I take his place?"

"…"

"…"

"With a recommendation, maybe…"

[2529] Bodhidharma is a figure associated with the origins of Chan Buddhism. The tale of drinking water from a skull is traditionally associated with the Korean monk Wonhyo; pairing it with Bodhidharma exaggerates Jeok Cheongang's age.

[2530] *Saju* is Korean fortune-telling based on the four pillars of a person's birth date and time. An office absent from one's *saju* is a fate one never expected.

That guy's a special kind of crazy.

Jeok Cheongang and I fell silent. Then Jeok Cheongang fixed Hyuk Mujin with a long look.

"Go. Unless you want to die."

"Yes, sir. I'm sorry."

"If you flap that twitchy mouth of yours one more time, this old man will have something to apologize to your parents for."

After delivering the threat in a chilling voice, he turned his glare on me.

"And you."

I quickly waved my hands.

"I don't need to join the Five Kings Hall."

"That's not what I meant."

"Then what?"

"What do you plan to do from here on?"

He was asking about more than my next move. Pride and worry mingled in his eyes as he looked at me.

"You've done well to come this far. I'll give you that. But from here on…"

"Old Master."

I cut him off before he could continue and shrugged.

"I'm not as much of a child as you think."

"…!"

"And I already know what you're going to say."

I wasn't lying. I could guess well enough what Jeok Cheongang wanted to tell me.

The real war was about to begin. Not a battle—a war. Countless lives would be sacrificed to decide who would rule the world.

The fights I had faced until now had never been easy, but it was obvious that even greater dangers would come crashing down upon us from here on out.

But…

"You said it yourself a moment ago. You asked me what I was hesitating for. You told me to simply move forward."

That was right. I'd keep moving forward, as I always had. In my own way.

"I'll hesitate a little, then charge ahead without hesitation."

Jeok Cheongang watched me smile. Then he gave a quiet laugh.

"If you're going to move forward, move forward. What's this about hesitating a little?"

"I can't help it. Somehow, I've ended up with a lot to protect."

I had blood relatives who were as precious to me as my own life. I had companions and subordinates to whom I could entrust my life. And I had a Master with whom I had formed a bond deep enough for me to throw my life away.

I could not—and should not—ever lose something precious again as I had in the past.

"I'll protect everything I have as I go."

"Hah. Greedy bastard."

Jeok Cheongang let out a short, hollow laugh before continuing.

"But that's the right answer."

"Huh?"

"Always be careful. Think. Whatever crisis comes for you, even if you face an opponent you can't possibly defeat, hold on to that feeling and come back alive."

"Old Master…"

"And remember."

His voice was different from usual. It was calm and warm, and it slipped into my ears.

"You're someone another person wants to protect, too."

At noon, dazzling sunlight pierced the earth.

Step. Step.

Several dozen people walked in the same direction. Women and men, middle-aged people and elders—they moved without hesitation until they reached their destination.

Creeeak. Boom!

A massive door swung wide open as they approached.

Above it, three characters written in a sweeping hand looked down on the people entering beneath them.

Alliance Leader's Hall.

At the heart of the Murim Alliance, it was where the great affairs of Murim were decided. The varied people entering it now were the pillars, great and small, that supported the martial world.

Two among them stood out.

Smack. Smack-smack.

One young man kept stuffing food into his mouth as he walked. Another watched him in silence.

They looked about the same age, but their builds and the air about them could hardly have been more different.

They did share two undeniable traits: both were prodigies seldom seen in Murim's long history, and both had won tremendous fame.

Perhaps that was why people kept watching them, from the moment they entered until well after they took their seats.

So those are the young men…

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung and Huashan Divine Dragon Cheongpung. I've never seen them this close. Is this really what they're like?

Incredible! What perfect muscles and bones. He's reached the Supreme Peak realm so young. How could anyone dismiss him as a boy barely past twenty?

There was wonder and admiration at finally seeing the young heroes they'd known only by rumor.

Pavilion Master or not, what an undisciplined attitude.

Tsk. His martial arts may be strong, but he still has some growing up to do.

Entrusting such important posts to boys like that? You'll regret it, Alliance Leader.

There was envy, jealousy, and disdain, too. Their thoughts were as varied as the people themselves.

The two young men remained unfazed. More precisely, they paid none of it any attention.

Smack, smack. Agu, agu-agu.

Jin Taekyung watched Cheongpung cram dumplings and meat into his mouth and muttered, "What the fuck, is he a martial artist or Agumon[2531]…?"

"Whah?"

"Nothing. Keep stuffing your face, Young Hero Cheongpung."

"Wahn one?"[2532]

"Afraid? What would I be afraid of? You're the one who scares me. And no, I don't want one, so swallow before you speak. Dumpling filling is flying all the way over here."

With a voice of utter resignation, Jin Taekyung reached toward the flying bits of filling.

Whoosh. Tick!

His fingers moved too fast for most Peak masters to follow. As he knocked aside the finely chopped meat and vegetables, gasps and exclamations rose around the hall.

"Gasp!"

"My word."

[2531] Agumon is a dinosaur-like character from *Digimon*. Its name echoes Cheongpung's "agu-agu" eating sounds.

[2532] Cheongpung's full mouth slurs *hana deuryeo?* ("want one?"), which Taekyung hears as *duryeowo?* ("afraid?").

The world was vast and masters were many, but not all of the several dozen people gathered here were Supreme Peak masters.

Even so, a simple movement could reveal something of a martial artist's ability.

Jin Taekyung was a Supreme Peak master who had opened his Middle Dantian. It would not be an exaggeration to say that his movements belonged to an entirely different realm.

The Fire King's successor… He lives up to his reputation. The rumors weren't exaggerated.

Damn it. What kind of monster is he?

If the Huashan Divine Dragon has reached the same realm… Hah. Astonishing.

As everyone watched the two young men with their own thoughts, a deep voice rang through the conference hall.

"The Alliance Leader is entering."

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"The Alliance Leader is entering."

At the sound of that deep voice, five doors opened one after another. A figure approached slowly from beyond them, and everyone rose as one, as though they had rehearsed it.

"Chomp, chomp. Smack, smack."

"…"

Everyone except this bastard.

The more I look at him, the crazier he seems.

I wasn't exactly a model of etiquette myself, but even I could read a room. I leaned toward Cheongpung, who was determined to store every last morsel of food safely in his mouth, and whispered, "What the hell are you doing? Got a problem with society? Don't like the Murim Alliance?"

Cheongpung swallowed and stood up before answering.

"But there's still food left, Benefactor."

"Then stop eating."

"But the dumplings will get cold."

"…"

You bastard, Cheongpung. You Guan Yu[2533] bastard. You know when dumplings are getting cold, but you haven't noticed everyone's stares turning cold…

Well, he's always been like this.

Cheongpung wouldn't be Cheongpung if he cared what anyone thought. I sighed, poked him in the side, and muttered, "If you're done eating, pay attention. Our esteemed Azure Dragon Pavilion Master."

At the words *Azure Dragon Pavilion Master*, Cheongpung pouted and nodded. His reply came out in a tiny, thoroughly disgruntled voice.

"Yes, Benefactor."

The name Two Dragons Pavilion remained unchanged, but it had been divided internally into my Fire Dragon Pavilion and Cheongpung's Azure Dragon Pavilion. On our way to the conference, Cheongpung had told me he'd wanted a different name. Mungyeong had fiercely opposed it.

"I don't like that name."

"Why? I think Azure Dragon Pavilion sounds pretty cool. Still, it's a little unfair. You're the Pavilion Master. Shouldn't you at least get to choose the name?"

"I thought so too, but Grandpa Mun hated my idea. He threatened to quit if I used a name like that."

[2533] In *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, the general Guan Yu defeats an enemy commander before his wine has time to cool. Taekyung likens Cheongpung's concern for his cooling dumplings to that episode.

"It was that bad? What name did you want?"

"Dumpling Pavilion."

"…"

"Or Sweetmeat Pavilion."

"…Oh. Right."

"Hoo. I hate Grandpa Mun. What's so great about Azure Dragon Pavilion, anyway?"

It was ridiculous even now. *You should be grateful, you lunatic.*

Why not just call it Gim Bugak?[2534] The words reached my throat, but I swallowed them. Not because the matter was already settled.

The highest authority in orthodox Murim had finally entered the conference hall.

Step.

Footsteps crossed the silence. Murim Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak reached the seat of honor and smiled at everyone.

"You're all here."

Unlike the previous meeting, this one included the heads of the key organizations under the Alliance Leader's Office. The Murim Alliance's internal reorganization was finally complete.

That's quite a crowd when we're all together.

I swept my gaze around the room. Some faces were unfamiliar—masters whose names and sobriquets I'd heard but whom I'd never met. Among the familiar faces were more than a few I was glad to see.

"You're awfully late. My backside was about to cramp up."

Even if you turned the whole world upside down and shook every soul out of it, you could count on one hand the people who could talk to Mae Jonghak like that.

Jeok Cheongang was the foremost among them. Standing with his weight on one leg beside the seat of honor, he spoke in his usual surly tone. Across from him, Jin Wikyung glanced around uneasily before speaking up.

"Great Hero Jeok."

"What?"

"Well, you know…"

"Good grief. Now that you've got a title, are you taking the Alliance Leader's side?"

Jin Wikyung paused for a moment and gave an awkward smile. In the space of just a year and several months, he had taken the helm of the Jin Family of Taiyuan as Acting Family Head and brought astonishing growth to a family that had been slowly declining. Before anyone knew it, he had become one of their number.

"It's not that—"

[2534] Gim bugak is a fried Korean seaweed snack. Its final syllable, *gak*, sounds like the word rendered "Pavilion" in the names above.

"I know. I know. Now both brothers are making a fuss."

Mae Jonghak smiled at the grumbling Jeok Cheongang.

"Don't be like that, Great Hero Jeok. Or should I call you the Five Kings Hall Master now?"

"…Hmph. I get your point, so stop. There are too many people watching."

"And here I am, wasting busy people's time with idle chatter."

It was hard to imagine anyone busier than Mae Jonghak, but he wasn't wrong. Every person gathered here was a vital cog in the vast Murim Alliance.

The Two Halls, Three Divisions, Five Pavilions, Five Gardens, and Ten Squads.[2535]

The only organization standing shoulder to shoulder with the Alliance Leader's Hall, led by Murim Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak, was the Five Kings Hall, now headed by Jeok Cheongang. Beneath them were the Three Divisions and Five Pavilions belonging to the Inner Hall, followed by the Five Gardens and Ten Squads, which were occupied by people from the Five Great Families and the Nine Sects and One Gang.

And there are more besides.

Remarkably, this wasn't everyone. Add the unit heads and commanders of the Outer Hall, and even this spacious conference hall wouldn't hold them all. They'd have to use the training ground.

It showed how enormous the Murim Alliance was. It also meant Cheongpung and I had been recognized as part of its central leadership.

Even if it's basically an honorary position with no real authority.

A difference between title and standing, perhaps. My title was Pavilion Master, but in the actual pecking order, I was near the bottom of this gathering. Of course, no one else my age held a position like it.

Ah. There was one other person besides Cheongpung.

One-Ride Heavenly Dragon Murong Yeonghwi, a genius who had been called Murim's greatest young prodigy only two years ago. He was the Lesser Family Head of the Murong Family and had recently been appointed a Squad Leader of the Murim Alliance's Outer Hall. I had heard that instead of following his father, the Family Head, to Henan, he had remained in Liaoning to oversee the family's defenses.

I thought I might finally get to see him in person.

Then again, there was no stupider act than leaving one's base undefended just to attend a meeting in Henan. Everyone else here must have completed their defensive preparations in the same way.

Swish.

Mae Jonghak slowly raised a hand.

[2535] The Korean names this group the "Ten Squads," but the parenthetical characters give "Nine Squads."

"Come, everyone. Sit down. We don't have time to stand on ceremony."

But no one sat. More precisely, no one could.

As Mae Jonghak raised his hand, something drifted up from beyond the doors, which still stood open.

"How can he use Seizing an Object Through Empty Space so effortlessly…?"

Someone muttered under their breath.

The object was covered by a cloth, so its identity could not be made out. But it was obviously enormous and seemed to possess considerable weight. Exclamations of admiration rose at Mae Jonghak's internal energy as he moved it without effort.

Several faces, though, had already gone rigid. Mine probably had too.

His internal energy isn't the issue. That thing…

Of my five senses, smell was the first to react. The odor was so faint that even a martial artist with sharpened senses might not have identified it right away. But I knew that stench the moment it reached me.

"Benefactor. Is that smell…?"

Cheongpung's eyes widened. I gave him a small nod.

"That's right. Corpse stench."

"…!"

The reek of a rotting body. I'd smelled it countless times in both the modern world and Murim, and this time I was more certain than anyone. A suspicion about the corpse's identity flashed through my mind.

If I'm right, that's…

The next moment, the cloth stained dark red with blood was pulled away, and everyone in the conference hall groaned almost simultaneously.

"Gasp."

"W-What in the world…?"

"Alliance Leader, what is that thing?"

Voices filled with shock burst out from every corner. Those who already knew about it and those who did not were all forced to feel the same shock at that moment. What the cloth had concealed was that horrifying.

A monster.

There was no other word for it. At a glance, it had a human shape, but unnaturally long, thick joints jutted grotesquely from all over its body. Its wide-open, lifeless eyes were each as large as a child's fist.

And that wasn't the end of it.

"Th-There's a horn."

"That's not all. Its arms…"

A black horn rose from the center of its forehead, and four arms protruded from its upper body. The arms varied in length and thickness, perhaps because they'd

been severed during the fight. But no one could dispute that they were human arms.

"Hmm."

"How could this happen?"

As the murmurs of dismay continued, someone spoke up.

"Infinite Life Buddha.[2536] It is hard to believe. I felt the same way at first."

The speaker was an old Daoist with deep-set eyes and a snow-white beard that reached his chest: the Sect Leader of Wudang. The people who turned toward him looked puzzled.

"At first…?"

"Do you mean…?"

The Sect Leader of Wudang nodded.

"That's right. Some of you may already have heard, but that man—no, that thing—was once a fisherman named Jang Sam."

The old Daoist was relating what I had heard earlier at the Hidden Shadow Pavilion. A fisherman with an ordinary name, no different from anyone else, had disappeared. One month later, he had reappeared as a monster and a Killing Ghost that had thrown Hubei Province into an uproar.

"When it was first found, its martial arts were only Third Rate. But its strength and movements were said to be inhuman. Each time it reappeared, it looked more grotesque and had grown stronger. As though…"

After a brief hesitation, the Sect Leader of Wudang continued with a sigh.

"As though it harmed people, absorbed their vital essence, and made it its own."

"…!"

The shock swept through the hall. Suffocating silence followed, until Jeok Cheongang frowned and spoke.

"Are you saying that goddamn monster learned the Essence-Siphoning Great Technique or something?"

The Sect Leader of Wudang shook his head.

"Infinite Life Buddha.[2537] I can't be certain of that either. But if that thing is what Dark Heaven intended to create, and it truly can use the Essence-Siphoning Great Technique…"

His voice trailed off. His face was rigid, and so were most of the faces around him.

Understandably.

[2536] "Infinite Life Buddha" is a religious invocation referring to Amitabha Buddha, who is associated with boundless life.

[2537] "Infinite Life Buddha" is a religious invocation referring to Amitabha Buddha, who is associated with boundless life.

The Essence-Siphoning Great Technique was a vicious demonic martial art said to have been lost even within the Demonic Cult. To orthodox martial artists, it was the work of a fiend.

If Dark Heaven had revived it and taught it to the monsters they'd created…

A catastrophe. Plain and simple.

Fortunately—or perhaps unfortunately—the Sect Leader of Wudang's guess was wrong. At least, as far as I knew.

Most monsters grow fast.

Didn't they say an Orc reaches adulthood in a month?

Most monsters grew stronger in one of two ways: they were born with tremendous power, or they absorbed magical power from other monsters.

Eating humans might give them a small amount of strength, but most of the people this thing killed were commoners and Third Rate or Second Rate wandering martial artists.

Humans and monsters were born with fundamentally different kinds of energy. If that sort of exchange between the two were possible, modern monsters would already be sold as aphrodisiacs or health tonics.

I can't be one hundred percent certain since it's a mutant.

Still, experience told me that explanation was more likely. No—I hoped it was. If monsters that could directly absorb human energy started pouring into the world, we'd never be able to handle them.

While I was lost in thought, Mae Jonghak's quiet voice carried through the hall.

"Pavilion Master Jin. What do you think?"

I turned my head toward the voice calling for Pavilion Master Jin—and froze when I felt everyone's gazes on me.

Wait. Pavilion Master Jin means…

Fuck. Me.

I still wasn't used to it, so I had forgotten.

"Are you asking me?"

"Yes. I'd like your opinion."

"Well, this is… Hm."

"It's all right. Say whatever comes to mind."

"I'm not sure how to put it."

"In your own way. Simply and clearly."

Simply and clearly. I thought for a moment, then spoke carefully.

"I think things are a little—no, maybe considerably…"

"Considerably?"

I stared into dozens of pairs of burning eyes before answering.

"I think we're fucked."

“…!”
“…!”

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A chilling silence settled over the great conference hall.

I'd expected that reaction before I opened my mouth. I'd even known which of the dozens gathered here would be the first to take a shot at me.

"Do you call that something to say?"

He never disappoints.

I clicked my tongue inwardly as the half-gray-haired man spoke up, just as if he'd been waiting for his chance.

I already knew his name and position. He'd glared at me so much during our last gathering that I'd wondered what his problem was. It turned out we had an indirect connection.

They say blood never lies.

Father and son did look alike. The sharply raised eyes, the arrogant gaze that looked down on everyone, even the way they spoke.

"It seems you didn't hear me."

The man was Hwangbo Gun, Family Head of the Hwangbo Family and father of the Shandong Fist Dragon, Hwangbo Ak. I blinked slowly at his question.

"Of course I heard you. How could I not?"

"Then why didn't you answer?"

"Because your question is ridiculous. I said it with my own mouth, so of course it was speech. Did I make some kind of animal noise?"

Beside me, Cheongpung pricked up his ears.

"Benefactor, can you make animal noises too?"

"Keep your mouth shut, Cheongpung. Unless you want to puke up those dumplings."

"Thank you…"

Hwangbo Gun's face twisted as he watched us.

"Do you not understand what kind of gathering this is?"

"Is there anyone here who didn't know?"

"And yet you speak so crudely in front of these esteemed Seniors!"

"That's why I was trying not to say anything. Besides, we should hear what the Seniors think. What do you say?"

At my sudden question, Mae Jonghak nodded.

"Fire Dragon Pavilion Master Jin is right. I have no problem with it. His words may be rough, but we need to face reality."

"A-Alliance Leader!"

I cut off Hwangbo Gun's panicked cry.

"Yes, we've heard the Murim Alliance Leader's esteemed opinion. While we're at it, what does our Five Kings Hall Master think?"

Jeok Cheongang looked at Hwangbo Gun as though he were a bug.

"Why the hell are you asking? We're fucked. Ignore that bastard's nonsense and keep going."

"Thank you for the fiery answer."

I turned to Hwangbo Gun and shrugged.

"That's what those esteemed Seniors have to say."

"…!"

There were plenty of people here who could be called Seniors, but none of them could compare to Jeok Cheongang and Mae Jonghak.

If the heads of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were squad-leading corporals with pull or sergeants nearing discharge, Murim Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak was the battalion commander, and Jeok Cheongang was the command sergeant major.

If you don't have the seniority, keep your mouth shut.

And it wasn't just seniority. Strip off the insignia and take Jeok Cheongang on as an equal, and one punch from the Fire King would lay you out.

That was why even the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect and one of the foremost among those who disliked Cheongpung and me, kept his mouth firmly shut.

Which left Hwangbo Gun all alone.

You should've looked before stretching out your legs. Why step forward on your own?

I'd heard Hwangbo Gun wielded considerable influence during the Great Faction War. Maybe he'd always lacked political sense. Or maybe a matter involving his only son—the sole heir in three generations—had turned him into a runaway locomotive.

I hummed a mournful tune.

"I'm a firefly. I have no friends."[2538]

"You insolent young punk!"

I couldn't stop there. I hit him with the combo I'd prepared.

"Waaah. I'm a baby Pavilion Master."

"You braaaat!"

Crash!

Hwangbo Gun sprang to his feet, veins standing out on his clenched fists. He glared at me, furious and empty-handed, without so much as breaking even.

Then a voice spoke.

[2538] A line from the Korean song *Gaettongbeolle* ("Firefly"), about loneliness.

“‘Punk,‘ you say… Forgive me, Family Head Hwangbo, but may I ask you one question?”

The voice was gentle, with a firmness beneath it. Jin Wikyung’s eyes had gone cold as he looked at Hwangbo Gun.

“What position do you hold within the Murim Alliance, Family Head Hwangbo?”

“…!”

“Regardless of how young the Fire Dragon Pavilion Master may be, he is the successor to Great Hero Jeok, the Fire King, and a Pavilion Master of the Murim Alliance. Even if we consider seniority within the martial world, he is certainly not beneath you, Family Head Hwangbo.”

That hit the sore spot. Hwangbo Gun’s face stiffened.

He was Family Head of the Hwangbo Family, the hegemon of Shandong, but within the Alliance he was only an Outer Hall Squad Leader charged with defending one region.

In the Murim Alliance’s official hierarchy, that put him below me, an Inner Hall Pavilion Master.

“That…”

Unable to continue, Hwangbo Gun bit his lip and looked around for help.

The response was lukewarm.

“Amitabha.[2539] Perhaps it would be best to restrain yourself now, Benefactor Hwangbo.”

“Heavens. Such a disturbance in the sacred Alliance Leader’s Hall.”

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—no, Fire Dragon Pavilion Master. I’m not taking your side. Both of you have said enough. Sit down.”

I answered without a hint of shame.

“I’ve been sitting down the whole time.”

“Then there’s only one person left.”

It was obvious whom he meant.

Hwangbo Gun was torn between his rational judgment, which told him he needed to stop, and the last shred of pride possessed by the hegemon of Shandong and Family Head of a great family.

One remark settled his indecision.

“Got a hidden weapon stuck in your ear?”

It came from the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. The air in the hall heated with those few words.

Hwangbo Gun stood frozen, reflected in Jeok Cheongang’s red-glowing eyes.

“Sit down. Right now.”

[2539] An invocation of Amitabha Buddha, commonly spoken by Buddhist monks.

"…!"

Whoooosh!

Jeok Cheongang's aura surged through the air and crashed over them. Hwangbo Gun's eyes flew wide.

So did everyone else's.

"Hmm."

Fist King Yan Hwapyeong, who had watched in silence, let out a low groan.

"J-Jeok! You bastard…!"

The Thunderbolt Saber King Peng Cheolhu's gaze wavered.

Jeok Cheongang's aura was that powerful, that overwhelming—like another sun. Those still in the Peak realm could feel his strength, as could those who had already reached Supreme Peak.

Returned to Youth.[2540]

The mountain range called martial arts was vast and treacherous. Sometimes one had to cross a steep ravine or scale a sheer cliff.

Jeok Cheongang was a great martial artist standing proudly atop the peak at the very end.

He had become something beyond his title of Fire King. So had one other person in this room.

"Great Hero Jeok."

At Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's quiet call, the hot wind sweeping through the hall vanished.

Jeok Cheongang drew in his aura at once and answered gruffly.

"Did something happen?"

"Hmm."

"All right, I know. That bastard was making too much noise, so I gave him a little scare."

No joke—if he scared Hwangbo Gun a second time, the man might wet himself. He was already back in his seat, white as a sheet.

"Finally, some quiet," Jeok Cheongang muttered.

Mae Jonghak gave him a gently reproachful look, then turned to me.

"Fire Dragon Pavilion Master."

"Yes."

"You have stood against Dark Heaven in Shanxi and Henan, and in Sichuan and Hubei."

Gotten dragged into it would have been more accurate, but I nodded.

[2540] A martial-arts concept in which extraordinary attainment restores a person's youthful appearance.

This was the great conference hall of the Murim Alliance. Dealing with Hwangbo Gun and discussing matters of such importance were two entirely different things.

"That's right."

"I expect few people know Dark Heaven as well as you. I would like to hear your opinion."

"I was merely present at those incidents. Hidden Shadow Pavilion probably knows the concrete details and what is happening throughout the world better than I do. I already told you everything I knew."

"I want to hear what you saw and experienced yourself. What the man who went through it all truly thinks."

There we go.

What I'd said before was only a lead-in. Demurring once or twice was the polite thing to do, and if Mae Jonghak, speaking with the authority of the Murim Alliance Leader, pressed me for my opinion, it would carry that much more weight.

All right.

I took a small breath.

Until now, I'd been sitting in the back seat. From here on, I was in the passenger seat.

I couldn't tell a driver setting out on an unfamiliar road at dawn, through thick fog and without navigation, everything I knew. But I could point out the speed bumps and warn him what lay ahead.

Including the ominous thought I haven't been able to shake lately.

I sorted through my thoughts and raised my head. Everyone in the hall was looking at me.

Dozens of pairs of eyes.

They were people who could save—or kill—hundreds, even thousands, of lives in a war that had already begun.

How much heed they would pay to a kid barely past twenty, I couldn't say.

It doesn't matter. If we can win this war. If I can reduce the danger and sacrifice even a little.

I had to do what I could. Right now.

Perhaps that was why my voice carried a weight it usually didn't when I began to speak.

"Dark Heaven…"

[2541] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

Two shichen later,[2541] everyone had left the great conference hall except three people.

The chairs that had held dozens of people stood empty, but the silence that had settled over the room remained. Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho suspected those who had left the Alliance Leader's Hall were just as quiet.

They had every reason to be.

Jin Taekyung's words had been that shocking.

Everyone knew Dark Heaven existed and understood that it was dangerous. No one, though, had warned of the coming crisis as forcefully as that young man.

Not even me.

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion gathered intelligence from across the realm and issued countless predictions. Hundreds of messenger pigeons arrived each day with information tied to their slender ankles, then flew off again before long.

As its chief, Song Ho knew how dangerous Dark Heaven was.

But…

The thinking of the Fire Dragon Pavilion's young master, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon whose actions had caused one upheaval after another, went far beyond anything Song Ho had expected.

Where others spoke of danger, Jin Taekyung foretold disaster. When someone cited the Great Faction War as grounds for believing the Murim Alliance would win, he answered sharply.

"Are we fighting the Demonic Cult? Our opponent is Dark Heaven. Dark Heaven."

"What Dark Heaven has shown us isn't simply demonic martial arts. So what do I call it? Ah, this is driving me crazy. Fine. Let's call it demonic martial arts for now."

"I don't know why Dark Heaven has gone quiet, but we need to use this opening to strike back immediately. If we keep going like this, we're finished. Everyone dies."

"Who said I was going too far? You, Family Head. Have you ever fought someone who came back to life even after all four limbs were crushed? Or fought an imugi?[2542] When you saw that monster half an hour ago, did you think about nothing but what to eat for dinner?"

"We aren't fighting ordinary people. Dark Heaven is one enormous monster, and before long, we may have to fight monsters like that one."

"I went a little too far. But this needs saying: we have to take every measure we can, right now. Especially if you've got a divine artifact at home that you guard like an ancestral shrine."

Song Ho suddenly furrowed his brow.

The place where his prosthetic leg attached had begun to throb when Jin Taekyung started speaking. Now it burned.

[2542] An imugi is a legendary Korean serpent associated with dragons.

It wasn't like this even a year ago.

The pain had returned at some point and begun tormenting him in his old age, as though warning him this was no time to sit still.

And today, that young man was here too.

It was as though he knew. As though he had experienced something in advance and was predicting some truth that I and the Hidden Shadow Pavilion—no, that everyone else—knew nothing about.

Foresee? No. Song Ho corrected himself.

It was more like a prophecy.

The question was whether it truly was one.

Could he trust the young man who, more than anyone else in the realm, had come into contact with Dark Heaven? How much of what he'd said was truth, and how much was exaggeration?

"Believe him."

"Hm?"

Song Ho looked up sharply. Jeok Cheongang, still in the hall, continued.

"I said, believe him."

"Great Hero Jeok."

"I know what you're going to say. But…"

His tone softened.

"The kid I know has never once been wrong."

"…!"

Song Ho faltered at the absolute trust in those words.

Then Mae Jonghak, the last of the three remaining in the hall, spoke.

"There are certainties in this world that information alone cannot lead us to."

"Alliance Leader. Do you mean…?"

"That's right."

Mae Jonghak rose slowly from his seat.

"Summon him. It's time to give the Fire Dragon Pavilion its first mission."

Chapter 548

"Well done."

Jin Wikyung said it the moment we left the great conference hall. I answered with a quiet laugh.

"Why are you laughing?"

"I don't know. Maybe because your expression doesn't match what you're saying?"

"Ah."

Only then did his stiff expression ease. But the smile at the corners of his mouth was so faint it looked ready to disappear.

"To be honest, I don't know what to make of what you said. Today, you were just so…"

"It's all right. That reaction is only natural."

I understood why Jin Wikyung trailed off. I could imagine how he felt.

If I were in his position, I'd react the same way.

In this world, the word *death* did not carry quite the weight one might expect.

Murders were rare in the modern world, and people learned about them through television and other media. Here, people witnessed death often.

Things were somewhat better in cities with good public order. Outside them, commoners lived under the threat of bandits or mounted bandits, depending on where they were.

Martial artists were another matter entirely.

A life spent walking on the point of a blade.

There was a reason people called it a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords.

They were always prepared to die. They stoked their fighting spirit and trained their martial arts. Jin Wikyung, standing before me, was a martial artist too.

The problem was the environment he and all the others had grown up in.

In Murim, people killed people, and people died by human hands. There were fierce beasts and spiritual creatures, but at least people knew what those were. They were not monsters no one had ever heard of or seen.

And today, I had told them those monsters would cover the world.

I had predicted a fight in which humans and monsters would kill one another.

I don't know how much of what I said sank in. But they must have felt the danger.

As I spoke, some looked at me with disbelief. Others were confused but fell into deep thought.

They did not all have to believe me right away. Getting them to listen was enough to accomplish what I had set out to do.

It only got through at all because they're martial artists and I had hard evidence.

If my audience had been a bunch of old Confucian scholars, they would have shouted "Confucius Akbar!"[2543] and staged a protest against supernatural powers. The people in the great conference hall were not quite that close-minded.

At least, not with the corpse of a four-armed monster lying in front of them.

There were the Water God Dragon's remains, too.

Its body had been separated into parts and was still being transported in strict secrecy. But I had quietly slipped some of its byproducts into my Inventory just in case. Those were enough to serve as important physical evidence.

"Come to think of it, Youngest. Where did you get that? I was sure every last piece had been collected."

"What?"

"You know. The imugi[2544] you defeated in Hubei…"

"Ahem. Ahem. Cough-cough-cough!"

I forced out a fit of coughing. Cheongpung, who had been listening beside us, rummaged through his robes.

"Benefactor. Would you like a sweetmeat? Sweetmeats are the best medicine for a cough."

"…No. They're the worst."

"Okay."

Since when were sweetmeats miracle medicine?

Denied a test subject, mad scientist Cheongpung looked dejected and put a sweetmeat in his own mouth. Jin Wikyung watched him and let out a quiet laugh.

"I understand. I won't ask again."

"Good. Thanks."

I scratched my chin awkwardly. Jin Wikyung watched me for a long moment, then spoke.

"Sometimes I wonder whether you—our youngest—are the same child I knew."

"…!"

"I won't ask you outright. Nor will I harbor any further doubts. But there is one wish I have never told you about."

His voice remained gentle.

"When all this is over, and the time is right, I'd like to hear the stories you haven't been able to tell me."

The stories I haven't been able to tell.

I repeated the words to myself.

When will that time come?

[2543] "Confucius Akbar" combines Confucius's name with the phrase *Allahu akbar*, meaning "God is greatest."

[2544] An *imugi* is a legendary Korean serpent associated with dragons.

But if all this really did end, as Jin Wikyung said, and I was ready… maybe I would tell him myself. The secret I had never been able to share with anyone.

Maybe that day would come.

"…I understand."

I gave him a bitter smile and nodded. At that exact moment, a voice called out.

"There you are, Fire Dragon Pavilion Master."

Tap.

A dull sound rang out with the elderly voice. I turned my head and saw Song Ho, the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion of the Murim Alliance—the Thousand-Faced Fox.

"The meeting ended half an hour ago, yet you're still here. Coincidence?"

I shook my head. Talking to Jin Wikyung was not the only reason I had stayed at the Murim Alliance.

"It must have been inevitable."

"Inevitability, is it? Yes, I suppose so."

Something flickered in those old, unreadable eyes. After a brief silence, the Thousand-Faced Fox spoke again.

"Come with me, Fire Dragon Pavilion Master. You know what this is about, don't you?"

I did. I knew who wanted to see me, and why.

His next words turned my guess into certainty.

"The Alliance Leader is looking for you."

Thud.

The door closed behind me with an unusually loud sound. Two people were already waiting in an office inside the Alliance Leader's Hall.

"You're here?"

After Jeok Cheongang's flat question, Murim Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak gestured toward a seat.

"Sit down. The rest of you, wait outside for a moment."

He was not speaking to me or the Thousand-Faced Fox, who had followed me straight into the office. He meant the others who had yet to show themselves.

Swish.

No sooner had Mae Jonghak spoken than several presences vanished like ghosts.

Even the secret guards said to remain at his side at all times had withdrawn. I sat in an empty chair.

"They're incredibly skilled. I could barely sense them."

“Most people who enter this room don’t notice them at all. It’s impressive that you did.”

“Even if they don’t know, wouldn’t they at least guess? It would be strange for someone as important as the Murim Alliance Leader to have no guards at all.”

“Ah. You have a point.”

Mae Jonghak scratched his chin like a young man my age, then looked at me. My face was reflected in his clear, deep eyes.

“First, I was impressed by what you said in the great conference hall.”

“I’m glad to hear it. I don’t know what the others thought.”

“They may not believe all of it, but they won’t dismiss it. I promise you.”

Even lightly spoken words carried different weight depending on who said them. And when the speaker was the Alliance Leader of the Murim Alliance, it was only natural for those words to carry tremendous authority.

That gives my argument more weight.

Things were going well. My expression must have relaxed, because Mae Jonghak smiled.

“You were worried.”

“I’d be lying if I said I wasn’t.”

“Since we’re on the subject, how certain are you of your claim?”

“Five out of ten. Fifty-fifty.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox’s face went rigid.

“Did you just say… five out of ten?”

“Yes. Is that lower than you expected?”

“Damn it, the opposite! You’re saying there’s a fifty-percent chance the world will be covered in monsters!”

There was a curse in his outburst, but no one cared about that now. Far from taking offense, I felt relieved.

Their reactions told me that, at the very least, the people gathered here had already accepted my claim as fact.

“What gives you that fifty percent?”

Mae Jonghak was still calm. I answered without hesitation.

“Everything I’ve seen and felt fighting Dark Heaven.”

Jeok Cheongang, who had been sipping strong liquor instead of tea, spoke up.

“You could be wrong.”

“I hope I am. They can curse me for the rest of my life if I am.”

I meant it. I would much rather be completely wrong. Maybe Dark Heaven would turn out to be nothing special, and no mutated monsters would ever appear.

If all it took to get a happy ending was for everyone to curse me, I’d take that deal.

But…

“It sounds insane, but it’s all true.”

“Damn it. This is driving me crazy.”

“Is it that hard to believe?”

“I don’t want to believe it. If it were anyone but you saying it, I wouldn’t.”

“…!”

Where did that sudden burst of emotion come from? What am I supposed to do with this?

Thud.

But emotional or not, to hell with all that. Jeok Cheongang slammed his liquor bottle down and glared at me.

“Tell me it’s a lie instead. If you confess right now, I’ll let you off with three strikes from the Flame Divine Palm.”

“I swear on my balls, right here and now, that I’m not making this up. Also, three strikes from the Flame Divine Palm would kill me.”

“Whew.”

Jeok Cheongang let out a deep sigh and turned to Mae Jonghak and the Thousand-Faced Fox.

“This old man doesn’t want to believe it either, but it seems the punk is telling the truth. He’s sincere when he puts his balls on the line, at least.”

“…”

That was a strange standard for deciding whether something was true. Still, I seemed to have gotten my sincerity across.

As what I feared settled over the office, silence fell. Mae Jonghak broke it.

“I have one more question.”

“You can ask two.”

“No. One is enough.”

Swish.

Mae Jonghak crooked a finger. A large scroll flew out from among the bamboo slips piled behind him and unfurled across our table.

Rustle.

I looked at what was written on it—no, drawn—and muttered, “This is…”

“You are looking at exactly what you think you are. A complete map of the realm.”

It showed the geography and terrain across the realm, with place names marked as well. But it was larger than any map I had seen in Murim, and there was another difference.

“It even shows where the sects are.”

“It was made for the Murim Alliance. Now, tell me…”

Mae Jonghak's calm voice reached my ears.

"Where do you think Dark Heaven will strike next?"

"I can't be certain."

"Who in this world can be certain of the future? A simple guess will do."

A simple guess…

I remained silent, lost in thought. Then, suddenly, I raised my hand and pointed to one part of the map.

Tap.

"Here."

The reactions were immediate.

Jeok Cheongang muttered a quiet curse. A sharp light flashed in the Thousand-Faced Fox's eyes, while Mae Jonghak leaned his upper body toward me.

"Why there?"

"If what happened in Hubei happens again, Dark Heaven would have a hard time finding a better place."

"You mean that 'rift.'"

"Yes."

"You're certain the rift will open again—or rather, you suspect it will?"

"I think there's every chance it will. What happened wasn't a natural disaster. Dark Heaven planned it and made it happen."

There can only be a first if there's a second.

I alone had been able to glimpse the Water God Dragon's memories, however briefly. I had no physical evidence I could offer with confidence, and I could not be certain. But there was a good chance Dark Heaven had its sights on *that place*.

I continued calmly.

"I don't know what Dark Heaven is going to do right now. This may not be its next target. But at least one person must have already set out for that place."

"The Southern Heaven Demon Empress."

At the sound of the title, the countless bodies I had seen in Hubei flashed before my eyes. My fist clenched.

"That's right. If it's the Southern Heaven Demon Empress… she must have that place in mind."

"Is that another simple guess?"

"A guess. One close to certainty."

I could not be sure of anything. But a thought that had been haunting me for some time seemed more and more likely.

Mae Jonghak nodded quietly and looked to Song Ho.

"What do you think, Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion?"

“I’ll add my voice to the Fire Dragon Pavilion Master’s.”

Song Ho answered at once, then continued.

“It has been more than seven days and nights since we sent a missive. With no reply yet, there’s a good chance something has already gone wrong.”

“I expected as much, but… that’s fast.”

“Yes. We could send the Outer Hall forces we selected in advance, but we risk arriving too late.”

A missive? Forces selected in advance?

The Thousand-Faced Fox read the question on my face.

“The Hidden Shadow Pavilion has eyes and ears throughout the realm. You weren’t the only one to make this guess.”

“…You had already been considering that place.”

“To be precise, we began considering it immediately after receiving a report on the circumstances surrounding what happened in Hubei Province. However, that strange phenomenon called a rift was something neither I nor anyone else in this Pavilion anticipated.”

I remembered something I had briefly forgotten. The elderly martial artist before me had been the head of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion forty years ago, and he still was.

And there was only one person in this room who could give orders to both of us.

“Fire Dragon Pavilion Master Jin Taekyung.”

Mae Jonghak’s voice rang through the office, heavier than usual.

Mae Jonghak, the great martial artist known as the Number One Sword Under Heaven and the man standing at the pinnacle of Murim today, stared at me with clear blue eyes.

“I’m giving you your first order.”

Whoosh!

A fierce wind rose with every step I took.

Ignoring the eyes of everyone around me, I even used my movement technique to hurry back to my residence. When I arrived, I flung open the door with all my strength.

Bang!

A familiar face came into view.

Hyuk Mujin had been lounging in the annex. He sprang to his feet, looked back and forth between me and the shattered door, and muttered,

“Welcome back… Wow. The owner is going to cry tears of blood. That door was replaced less than half an hour ago.”

I had no time to sympathize with the owner. Instead of greeting Mujin, I gave him an order.

“Summon everyone.”

“What?”

Hyuk Mujin stared at me, dumbfounded.

“What are you talking about all of a sudden? Wait, summon what?”

“The Fire Dragon Pavilion.”

“What?”

“It’s a mission. Right now.”

“Wait. Hold on! Captain, why all of a sudden? Where are we going?”

I answered the wide-eyed Hyuk Mujin in a low voice.

“Nanman.”[2545]

[2545] *Nanman* is a historical Chinese term for peoples and regions south of China; it can carry a derogatory sense.

Chapter 549

I wasn't a general leading an army of thousands.

Even counting me, the Fire Dragon Pavilion had only six members. Half an hour was enough to get everyone in one place.

"Everyone, listen up."

I offered no greeting or honorifics. Sensing something unusual in my abrupt command, all five turned their attention to me. Even Hyuk Mujin, who had gone to summon them, still had no idea what was going on.

I looked from one questioning face to the next, then began.

"To get straight to the point… I've been given a mission."

There was nothing to leave out and nothing to add. I told them exactly what I knew, and the briefing took less than fifteen minutes.

Afterward, everyone fell silent, lost in thought. Then one of them spoke.

"So," said a familiar, composed voice.

Sama Pyo, Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, looked at me.

"We're heading to Nanman.[2546]"

I nodded, with one small correction.

"To the Nanman Beast Palace, to be precise."

The Nanman Beast Palace was a mysterious sect said to tame countless animals, including spiritual creatures and venomous beasts, and practice martial arts modeled on their movements.

I couldn't tell whether they were an animal welfare society or a bunch of animal abusers. One thing, though, was certain.

Honglan. No—the Southern Heaven Demon Empress would be salivating over that place.

If a second rift opened, Dark Heaven would be hard-pressed to find a better location than the Nanman Beast Palace. It was an animal kingdom, teeming with more spiritual creatures and venomous beasts than anywhere else under heaven.

Song Ilseom had been listening with his willow-leaf saber held against his chest. He muttered, "We're in for a rough trip."

He had good reason to think so.

Nanman, where the Beast Palace stood, was also called Yunnan in the Central Plains. It lay directly south of Sichuan and bordered Guizhou and Guangxi. Put like that, it sounded merely far away. But…

The problem is, Nanman's terrain and climate are unbelievably fucked.

[2546] Nanman is a historical Chinese term for lands and peoples south of the Central Plains, literally "southern barbarians." Here it refers to Yunnan.

I'd heard it was sweltering hot, with jungles that went on forever. There wasn't a decent road to be found. Instead, it had full-grown predators and venomous insects that treated humans like food delivery.

And that's just what I've heard…

I couldn't imagine what it was like in person. I was beginning to understand why Nanman was considered part of the Outer Lands, despite having a perfectly respectable place on maps of the realm.

Though from a modern perspective, it really is a foreign country.

In the modern world, was Yunnan Vietnam or Myanmar? It had to be somewhere around there, but my memory was hazy because I'd spent world geography class sleeping my ass off.

While I was trying to dredge it up, Hyuk Mujin shot his hand into the air.

"Captain, I have a question."

"Go ahead."

"Are we really going?"

"Would we be going fake?"

"It's just… it sounds too dangerous."

"So what? It's always been dangerous."

"…When you put it like that, I've got nothing to say."

"Then shut up and pack."

"When are we leaving?"

"Oh. Did I forget to mention that?"

That was important. The others must have been so focused on where we were going and why that it hadn't occurred to them either.

I looked at each of them in turn and dropped the answer.

"Today. Right now."

"…!"

"…!"

A ripple went through the group, especially Hyuk Mujin and Taishan, the Tiger Giant Child.

"You're joking, right?"

"Do I look like I'm joking?"

"That's impossible. What about clothes and supplies? We'd have to pack everything right now."

"It's possible. Since when have we worried about having every little necessity? Just bring some fasting pills."

Huff! Huff!

What the hell? Was that Scorching Yang Qi?

Taishan blew an astonishingly hot breath through his nose and leaped to his feet.

“No! Taishan! Eating meat tonight!”

“Meat? Meat sounds good.”

I turned to Hyuk Mujin. “You heard him. Bring jerky too.”

“Jerky! Tastes bad!”

“…Just shut up and eat whatever the hell you get.”

The guy looked capable of chewing up a pair of chopsticks, and *he* was picky?

Sama Pyo caught the look I gave him and shrugged.

“Taishan. You little rascal.”

“L-Lord.”

“How long do you intend to carry on like this? If you keep throwing tantrums…”

“Taishan. Won’t do it. Forgive Taishan, Lord.”

The enormous man looked so dejected that I actually felt sorry for him.

I’ll leave Taishan to Sama Pyo from now on.

I turned to Song Ilseom, who was frowning.

“What? You’ve got a problem with it too?”

“Of course. We’re going to Nanman, of all places.”

He clicked his tongue.

“But I’ll act as though I don’t. Unfortunately, I’ve already taken a hefty advance, and I can’t afford to pay a penalty ten times that amount.”

“You’re much more straightforward than I expected. I like it.”

“When I make a contract, I honor it. If I didn’t, I’d never have earned the name Soul-Chasing Guest.”

He said it with quiet conviction and pride, then continued matter-of-factly.

“Of course, the final decision isn’t mine. It’s my employer’s. Isn’t that right?”

Naturally, he wasn’t asking me.

Ju Hwaran, the Dagger Hidden Flower, had been silent and deep in thought the whole time. At last, she spoke.

“I think you already know my answer. Don’t you?”

At the sound of her clear, gentle voice, I let out a quiet laugh. Song Ilseom sighed.

“I knew it. Damn it, Nanman.”

“I trust I don’t need to remind you of the terms of our contract, Great Hero Song.”

Leaving him to groan, Ju Hwaran turned her gaze on me.

My face was reflected in her dark blue eyes. They held a mysterious light. From this close, they looked almost…

“Great Hero Jin?”

“Ah, yes.”

What was that? Did I doze off for a second?

Her voice brought me back to my senses.

No. I can't do that.

Not now. With what lay ahead, I needed to keep a clear head at all times.

I told myself that a few more times, pulled myself together, and spoke as calmly as I could.

"Good. There's something I wanted to ask you. Specifically…"

"The fastest route to Nanman and what we'll need? All right."

"Pardon?"

"Was I wrong?"

"No. It's not that."

Quite the opposite. She'd guessed so precisely that she'd startled me.

What the hell? Can she read minds? Is that some kind of mind-reading technique?

I could only blink at her. Ju Hwaran smiled.

"There's no need to be surprised. I've been thinking about what I can do to help."

"Oh."

"I'm officially a member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion now. As I said before, I ought to do my share."

Tap. Tap-tap.

Her pale, rough fingers drummed steadily on the table, a reminder that she was a swordswoman too.

"First, as you said, Great Hero Jin, we should keep supplies to a minimum. We won't need extra clothing, and two days' worth of dry rations should be enough."

"Dry rations? Please! Anything but that! Taishan will die!"

Ju Hwaran quickly added, "And jerky, of course."

"What the hell is his guardian doing? Ah, Young Lady Ju, please go on."

"Of course. Now…"

With the interruption dealt with, Ju Hwaran continued without a pause. She covered everything from the supplies we'd need to the fastest route to Nanman.

Fortunately, she had traveled there on an escort assignment several years ago. She also knew the terrain and hidden roads in various places from the records her grandfather, the Escort King, had left behind.

Even Song Ilseom, who had roamed the realm as a wandering martial artist since he was a snot-nosed kid, was surprised.

"There's a road like that?"

Ju Hwaran nodded with confidence.

"Of course. According to my grandfather's records, it's definitely there."

"I spent about a year there myself. But as far as I know…"

"According to my grandfather's records, it's definitely there."

"Yes, I know. What I'm saying is—"

"My grandfather's records."

"Would you let me finish?"

"The Escort King."

"…I believe you. I believe you, so please continue."

And who was the Escort King? The legend among legends who had completed his legendary Ten-Thousand-Li Journey[2547] while a hundred thousand Demonic Cultists covered the realm.

Ju P. Hwaran[2548] had inherited the will of that very P-King. Like the Going Merry[2549] on open water, she sailed ahead without a hitch. Before half an hour had passed, she'd planned every leg of our route to Nanman.

"Whew. That's everything for now. Any questions?"

Whoosh!

An arm thick enough to make me suspect it belonged to a Troll shot up.

"Yes? Ask away."

Tiger Giant Child Taishan opened his mouth with a stiff expression.

"Taishan. Understood nothing after jerky."

"…"

"…"

Which bastard brought a kid into a no-kids zone?

I glared at Sama Pyo.

"Hey, guardian."

"My apologies."

Smack.

"Mmph! Mmph!"

Sama Pyo clamped a hand over Taishan's mouth at once, then gave Ju Hwaran a small nod.

"My apologies."

"…It's all right."

Her tone was calm, but she could not hide the lowered voice that accompanied it. Given the circumstances, it could not be helped.

No, it was only natural.

Even if it was a political marriage, they were engaged.

[2547] A Chinese *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi); ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

[2548] The "P" plays on *pyo*, the first syllable of *pyo-wang*, the Korean title translated here as "Escort King." The joke carries that initial into Ju Hwaran's name.

[2549] The Going Merry is a ship in the Japanese manga *One Piece*.

Maybe those big-nosed Hollywood bastards, supposedly as cool as ice magic, could shrug off something like that. But the Korea I'd lived in and Murim were both full of Confucian girls and Confucian boys.

It was awkward even for me to watch. How much worse must it have been for Ju Hwaran?

And I don't even know what happened between them.

The thought left me feeling strange. Suddenly, the fabric against my skin irritated me, as if someone I couldn't see were pricking me over and over with a tiny, thin needle.

"Captain?"

"Hm?"

Hyuk Mujin's voice broke through my thoughts. I didn't need to turn my head to know the others were staring at me.

I pulled myself together and tried to sound casual.

"All right. We'll follow the plan we've discussed. Minimal supplies. As for how long we have…"

Ju Hwaran answered when I looked at her.

"Half a shichen.[2550] Even allowing extra time, that should be enough. We need to arrange the horses and carriages without attracting attention."

"Where should we gather?"

"Hmm. What do you think, Great Hero Jin?"

This wasn't a public mission. We had to move as quickly as possible, but discreetly too. To slip away from this crowded area unnoticed, we would first have to split up and choose a second meeting point.

"Mount Daebyeol. We'll meet there."

"Good idea."

Ju Hwaran and the others nodded at the answer I had settled on after careful thought.

[2550] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Chapter 550

After everyone left, Hyuk Mujin hurried off to gather what we needed, leaving me alone. I spoke quietly.

“Quest Window Open.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Journey to Nanman
Murim Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak has given the Fire Dragon Pavilion its first mission.
You must now head to Nanman and respond proactively to whatever circumstances may arise.
What lies ahead for you and the Fire Dragon Pavilion is unknown.
Always remain alert and act with a flexible mindset.
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung and Fire Dragon Pavilion members
Mission: Enter Nanman (Incomplete)
Reward: Linked Quest
???
Failure: Gain the Title Can’t Go to Nanman
Fame and Trust drop significantly.

The Journey to Nanman Quest had appeared when Mae Jonghak gave me the mission.

Judging by the description and mission field, the System wasn’t offering any useful hints this time.

There’s no time limit, either.

Not because we had plenty of time. Given how little we knew about what lay ahead, I didn’t think it was an overreaction to read it the other way.

I sighed quietly and closed the Quest Window.

If nothing happens, that’ll be a relief in its own way…

But if something did happen, it could spiral out of control. I would have to lead the Fire Dragon Pavilion, bring the situation under control quickly, and get everyone home safely.

I could barely look after myself, and now I was responsible for other people. The words *Pavilion Master* weighed on me more heavily than ever.

“Um…”

A voice abruptly slipped into my ear.

I turned to find Cheongpung standing before the half-destroyed door, a bundle in his hands, staring at me blankly.

“Benefactor, may I come in?”

“Anyone listening would think you always ask permission before coming in.”

When the door was intact, he’d barged in without so much as a knock. Now he was asking permission in front of the wreckage. I couldn’t believe him.

I let out a quiet laugh and waved him in.

“Just come in. I was going to see you anyway, so this works out.”

“I was going to come in whether you gave permission or not.”

The answer, of course, hadn’t come from Cheongpung.

I looked at Mungyeong, who had appeared like a ghost, and muttered, “I was talking to Cheongpung.”

“And I told you. I don’t need your permission.”

Mungyeong strolled into the annex and glanced at the cups on the table and the chairs left out of place.

“You had visitors. Six people in total, including you and Hyuk. One was a woman.”

“How did you know?”

“I can tell by looking.”

Cheongpung added innocently, “I saw the others leaving. I thought I should come when no one else was here.”

“…”

“…”

What the fuck?

Mungyeong met my suspicious stare with an expression that said *What are you going to do about it?*

“By looking,” he repeated.

“So when you said ‘by looking,‘ you meant you literally saw them?”

“I could have worked out something this simple without seeing them.”

“Don’t stare off toward the mountains. There are so many buildings around here you can’t see any.”

“I can see your future instead. Say one more word, and I have a feeling this room will smell of blood.”

“…”

Damn old man. And he goes around pretending to be a medical apprentice.

I shuddered at the phony medical apprentice’s vicious behavior and turned to Cheongpung.

“So what brings you here?”

"I came to say goodbye."

"What?"

Cheongpung scratched the back of his head and smiled.

"When you told me to go on ahead outside the Alliance Leader's Hall, I had a feeling you'd be leaving soon, Benefactor. Hehe."

I hadn't told him, but he'd guessed.

After a moment's hesitation, I nodded. "That's right. I have a mission."

"Ah! Where are you going?"

"Nanman."

"Nan…man?"

Cheongpung's eyes widened. Mungyeong thought for a moment, then murmured, "Nanman. The Beast Palace?"

"Yes."

"That strange phenomenon. It must be because of the rift."

"That's right. If a second rift opens, Dark Heaven would have a hard time finding a better place for it."

"It's certainly possible. Nanman is far from the Central Plains, and the route is difficult. If the Nanman Beast Palace falls, chaos will spread from Yunnan like wildfire."

I thought so too.

If Dark Heaven really was plotting something in Nanman and succeeded, the flames of war wouldn't stop at Yunnan Province.

They'd spread to neighboring Guizhou and Guangxi—and to Sichuan, which took considerable damage in the last battle.

Guizhou and Guangxi were particularly vulnerable. Both provinces had fewer sects and martial artists than other regions, and those they had were weaker. The flames would spread faster there.

"Nanman, at a time like this," Mungyeong said. "It'll be a difficult journey."

"If nothing happens, great. If something does… we'll stop it, whatever it takes."

"With only six of you?"

"A whole six."

"…?"

"I've heard one of them is a young, handsome Supreme Peak master taught by the Fire King and the Slaughter Saint. Ever heard of him?"

"No. I've certainly never heard anyone call him handsome."

"Ah. Right."

He cut me off without a moment's hesitation.

Having put an end to my nonsense, Mungyeong turned to Cheongpung.

“I have heard another rumor, though. About someone mad for dumplings who’s latched onto a young medical apprentice and is learning martial arts by watching him.”

“Huh?”

What did I just hear?

It must have shown on my face. Mungyeong nodded.

“It’s probably exactly what you’re thinking.”

“Really?”

“It’s true.”

“But why pass up the almighty Sword Saint to learn from someone with such a foul temper—sorry. That came out wrong.”

Mungyeong had somehow drawn a small sword from his sleeve. I avoided his chilling gaze and looked at Cheongpung.

“If he’s threatening you, blink twice.”

“You little bastard…”

“Hehe. It’s all true, Benefactor.”

I studied Cheongpung, then shrugged. “I know. I was joking.”

I didn’t need anyone to tell me why he’d sought out Mungyeong, or what he hoped to gain from him.

To become stronger. To change himself to fit this world.

It had been more than a year.

I’d been on my way to an inn when some ragged young man had walked up and asked me for a single sweetmeat. Despite Hyuk Mujin’s protests, I gave him every one I had. That was how I met Cheongpung.

We’ve both changed a lot.

The Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, once called the family’s disgrace, had become a Supreme Peak master who shook Murim. And the young genius who loved martial arts and delighted in everything the world had to offer, large or small, had developed a firm resolve somewhere along the way.

You couldn’t see the change, but you could feel it. Only a handful of people close to Cheongpung, myself included, knew it was there.

Tap.

I reached out and patted his shoulder. His eyes went round.

“Benefactor?”

“Nothing. Just telling you to hang in there.”

He stared at me for a moment, then his eyes curved into crescents.

“I will. You too, Benefactor.”

“I’m the one who needs to hang in there. At least you’ve got someone you can lean on. I don’t even have a hill.”

Mungyeong, who had been watching us in silence, spoke up.

“Come to think of it, I don’t see that hill.”

“That hill is staying in Henan. The rest of us are going without him.”

“Well, now I’ve seen everything. To think the Fire King would make that decision.”

“It’s embarrassing to say, but let’s call it the greater good. We need as many hands as we can get right now.”

Even as I answered, I felt a hollow place in my heart.

Maybe it was because this would be the first time since I’d met Jeok Cheongang that we’d gone our separate ways. Even when he’d been unconscious for so long, we’d stayed together.

But it’s time for me to stand on my own.

Jeok Cheongang’s arms were wide enough to shelter me, but I’d grown too quickly to stay in them. And with everything changing around us, we could no longer keep traveling together.

Could it be…?

A thought struck me, and I glanced out the window.

The faces passing along the main road were all unfamiliar, blurred together in the distance. The person I was waiting for never appeared.

Come on. That’s a little harsh.

He could at least have come to see my face before I left.

The words lingered on the tip of my tongue, then faded. I’d already said goodbye before leaving his office with my mission, but I couldn’t help feeling disappointed. Before I was a Hunter or a martial artist, I was a person.

“…I’ll see him again soon.”

“What was that?” Mungyeong asked.

“Nothing. Just talking to myself.”

I was about to look away from the window when a small baggage carriage came rattling toward the annex.

That would have been an ordinary sight anywhere, not just in Henan—if the man on the driver’s bench hadn’t been a disguised Peak master.

Song Ilseom.

Finally.

Ju Hwaran must have finished all the preparations within half a shichen[2551], just as she had boasted, and sent a carriage that could leave Henan discreetly.

I could already sense Hyuk Mujin coming up the stairs.

Time to go?

[2551] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

I'd grown used to this annex. But it seemed I was fated to spend this life on the road.

I gave the place one last look, then turned to my visitors.

"I'd better get going before it gets any later. Thank you for coming to see me. You too, Cheongpung."

Cheongpung hesitated, then thrust out the bundle he'd been holding all this time.

"This is for you, Benefactor."

"What is it?"

"Dumplings. I bought them from the best shop in Henan. I wanted to eat them, but I thought of you and held back."

Mungyeong added quietly, "He stuffed down at least five on the way here. That's how much he held back."

"Ah! Aah…"

I'd known what was in the bundle from the smell, but I was touched all the same. The missing five didn't change that.

"Thanks. I'll enjoy them. I'd better go."

I laughed quietly, took the bundle, and turned away. Then a line of Sound Transmission reached my ear.

—Do you know? Everyone who has received my teachings up to now has died.

"…!"

—So don't die a pointless death. If you die in Nanman, all that I've put up with until now will have been for nothing.

What a terrifying way to show concern. But like the dumplings in my hands, his feelings had come through clearly.

I stood there and gave a small nod before immediately setting off.

Step.

It was a powerful stride that echoed unusually loudly.

Chapter 551

On the night six young men and women slipped secretly out of Henan, two men clinked wine cups in a moonlit pavilion.

Clink.

The cups tilted with a clear ring. Fire King Jeok Cheongang drained his wine in one gulp and muttered, “The wine doesn’t taste right tonight.”

Mae Jonghak smiled from across the table. “Perhaps Yeoahong[2552] isn’t to your taste.”

“I don’t know. My throat’s been scratchy and my tongue bitter for a while now. You haven’t poisoned it, have you?”

No one else could have said that, even as a joke. Only Jeok Cheongang could—and only Mae Jonghak, sitting opposite him, could laugh it off.

“Me, poison Great Hero Jeok? Never. Though I may try it someday.”

“Do your research first. I’m confident I could withstand even Formless Ultimate Poison now.”

“Oh. Then I’ll look into it, even if I have to put the full strength of the Murim Alliance behind the effort.”

Jeok Cheongang answered gruffly. “How frightening. Anyone listening might think you were serious.”

“Oh, that was a joke? And here I thought…”

“…?”

Surely not.

Mae Jonghak nodded as though he had only just realized it was a joke, sending a chill down Jeok Cheongang’s spine.

What a lunatic old man.

His looks had grown younger, but he was just as insane as he’d been forty years ago. Then again, Jeok Cheongang didn’t have to look that far back for proof. Cheongpung alone made it obvious.

Like master, like disciple. Those two…

His hand jerked as he filled his cup.

Disciple.

Wine splashed over the brim. Reflected in it was the bitter expression of a middle-aged man.

Jeok Cheongang gazed at his own face, familiar yet still strange, then spoke without warning.

“Nothing will happen to him, will it?”

[2552] Yeoahong is a traditional Chinese rice wine whose name literally means “Daughter’s Red.”

Mae Jonghak filled his own cup. “Are you worried?”

“Worried? Why would I be? Once a man’s past twenty, he ought to go his own way. He’s old enough to start a family.”

Jeok Cheongang tried to sound confident, but his mouth still tasted bitter. He was thinking of someone who must be heading south by now.

Mae Jonghak caught the emotion that briefly crossed his face.

“He can’t have gone far.”

“Even though we already said our goodbyes, what would be the point of seeing him again? It would only make it harder to leave.”

“Now that you mention it, I suppose you’re right.”

“So? What’s your answer?”

“Hm? To what?”

“You become Alliance Leader and suddenly go deaf? You know… what I asked you earlier.”

Jeok Cheongang toyed with his cup before continuing more cautiously.

“Nothing will happen to him. Right?”

Mae Jonghak thought for a moment. “Maybe. Maybe not.”

“…You call that an answer?”

“Well, it was something I said. It just came out of my mouth.”

“Damn it. You’re driving me insane. Anyone could give me an answer like that!”

“Oh. I suppose that’s true.”

“Then give me a proper answer as Alliance Leader. A proper answer!”

Mae Jonghak smiled at Jeok Cheongang’s outburst.

“He’ll do fine. Just as he always has.”

“You mean that?”

“Of course. If I didn’t believe in him, why would I have entrusted the Fire Dragon Pavilion with such an important mission?”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice softened. “Have you made preparations in case things go wrong?”

“The Hidden Shadow Pavilion has eyes and ears throughout the realm. Nanman[2553] is no exception.”

“…!”

“Sending the Fire Dragon Pavilion to Nanman[2554] is the fastest and most reliable option. We don’t have enough time to raise an army right now.”

[2553] Nanman is a historical Chinese term for lands and peoples to the south, outside the central regions of China.

[2554] Nanman is a historical Chinese term for lands and peoples to the south, outside the central regions of China.

The Murim Alliance was by no means smaller than it had been during the Great Faction War. If anything, it was larger. Shaolin Temple, the Sichuan Sect, and several other sects had suffered heavy losses, but not a single province in the Nine Provinces[2555], still the territory of the orthodox faction, had fallen.

The problem was the time and supplies it would take to gather troops and send them to Nanman[2556]. The Fire Dragon Pavilion, led by Jin Taekyung, was one of the few cards the Murim Alliance could play with confidence.

"Hmm."

None of this eased Jeok Cheongang's worry. As he silently glared at his cup, Mae Jonghak muttered almost too softly to hear.

"There is one especially reliable source of support."

"Hm? What was that?"

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

"Don't try to fool me! I heard you say something with these ears!"

"Calm down and finish your drink. Then I'll think about it."

Jeok Cheongang stared at him. "Why do you keep trying to make me drink this tasteless wine?"

"Great Hero Jeok."

"What?"

Mae Jonghak held his gaze. "You've already drunk five jars of that tasteless wine."

"…"

"You're on your sixth."

"…"

"Let's drink."

Jeok Cheongang fell silent and raised his cup. The fragrant wine slid down his throat, nowhere near as bitter as he'd claimed. Moonlight touched his face as he tipped his head back.

I wonder where he is down there.

Heartless brat. You could've at least shown your face once before leaving.

The words in his heart scattered on a breeze that came from somewhere.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

[2555]The Nine Provinces is a traditional name for the lands of China, not a reference to nine modern administrative provinces.

[2556]Nanman is a historical Chinese term for lands and peoples to the south, outside the central regions of China.

The old horse walked slowly, and the straw packed around my entire body was cold and prickly. Outside the carriage, the voices of hawkers and passersby gradually faded.

Did we make it out?

The thought had barely crossed my mind when someone whispered in my ear.

"Captain. I need to take a shit."

"…"

Hyuk Mujin, you insane bastard. You're really doing this here?

We needed to move as little as possible, which meant I could not even subdue him by force. I lowered my voice as much as I could and barked, "You lunatic. I told you to go before we left."

"I'm nervous. That's why. I'm nervous."

"Then hold it, you son of a bitch."

"Why are you swearing at me? I can't say a thing around you."

"How am I supposed to *not* swear? What are we going to do about the smell if you shit in here?"

Even a fart under the same blanket would make me swear. I refused to suffer anything worse while we were buried together in straw.

"I've been thinking about that. If I just went, wouldn't the smell make it easier to get through inspection?"

"Die. Please, just die."

"I'm sorry. I've held it as long as I can, but I don't think I can hold it anymore. This might be the end for me."

"Hey, Mujin. Wait. Just wait a second."

"I'll accept my punishment later."

No! You bastard!

I was so terrified I was about to spring up, disguise be damned, when—

"We've passed through the center of Luoyang. We're on an empty mountain road now, so you can come out for a moment."

"Gasp!"

"Phew!"

Rustle!

Hyuk Mujin burst through the straw and sprinted toward the bushes. Saved at the edge of a cliff, I bowed repeatedly to my savior.

"Thank you. I'll be a good person. Thank you so much."

"The inspection must have taken a while for Hyuk Mujin to be that desperate. I'm glad we weren't too late."

The voice was familiar. The smiling woman's face was not.

In the moonlight spilling between the high branches, the freckles across her cheeks and her dry, rough skin stood out.

No matter how many times I look, it's amazing.

Her features and a few small details had changed, yet the whole impression she gave was different.

Ju Hwaran noticed me staring and touched her face. "Ah, I have changed a little, haven't I?"

"Yes. But your eyes are still the same."

A smile flickered in her beautiful dark-blue eyes.

"That isn't something a disguise mask can alter. If Captain Song hadn't helped, it would have been difficult to obtain a mask this good on such short notice."

Song Ilseom, sitting on the driver's bench, added flatly, "It was nothing. Just a little trick I learned to survive."

"That's impressive for a little trick."

"I assume that's empty praise, but I'll thank you for it."

That bastard has to take everything the wrong way. I meant it.

Song Ilseom had made the mask that turned Ju Hwaran into someone else entirely. I knew he'd started at the bottom and been through all kinds of hardship, but I hadn't expected him to know how to make disguise masks.

He's more useful than I thought.

The things he'd learned as a wandering martial artist would surely help us on the road ahead. I was admiring him in spite of myself when a thought made my eyes widen.

"Wait. Why don't I have one?"

If I had a disguise mask, I wouldn't have needed to ride like a piece of luggage beside a shit bomb that might go off at any moment.

Song Ilseom clicked his tongue at my protest. "Everyone's features are different. Just making the mold for a disguise mask takes days. How was I supposed to make yours in the time we had? A poorly fitted mask would only draw more attention. If you're so upset, you should have learned a disguise technique."

Hyuk Mujin emerged from the bushes looking thoroughly relieved and joined in.

"Then what about Young Lady Ju? You said it takes days."

"The Young Bureau Head's mask…"

Song Ilseom trailed off, then frowned. "What a pointless question. Shut up and get back under the straw. And keep that shit smell out of my face."

"You shit too. What are you getting on my case for…?"

Song Ilseom glared as Hyuk Mujin grumbled his way back into the straw, then turned to me.

"Can I cut him?"

"No."

I turned to Ju Hwaran. "The others must be out by now, right?"

She knew whom I meant and gave a small nod. "Probably. They went through the West Gate, where inspections are the weakest. They should have left Luoyang ahead of us."

Taishan's size worried me, but Ju Hwaran had planned too carefully to overlook it. Besides, we had the Alliance Leader's Hall and the Hidden Shadow Pavilion behind us. I could afford to relax.

Rustle.

Hyuk Mujin poked his head out of the straw. "Are we going straight to Mount Daebyeol, then?"

"Of course. We'll change horses once along the way, but nothing will happen before then."

Ju Hwaran continued without pause. "If we keep moving, two shichen[2557]. With thorough inspections, it could take three shichen[2558]. Once we meet the other two at Mount Daebyeol…"

"We leave Henan immediately. Correct?"

She smiled and nodded. "Just as you said, Pavilion Master."

"…Pavilion Master?"

"Why? Isn't that the right title?"

Technically, it was. It just felt like a set of clothes that didn't fit. I smacked my lips and nodded.

"Well, never mind that. We shouldn't have any problems before Mount Daebyeol, then?"

"Not at all. You could have a good long sleep and wake up before we arrive."

Henan was the Murim Alliance's base. An enemy attack here was all but impossible. Still, I let out a quiet laugh, neither agreeing nor disagreeing.

"What is it?"

"Nothing."

How could I put it? I thought for a moment before going on.

"It just feels strange to think I'll be dreaming again after so long."

"Dreaming?"

"Yes. I dream sometimes. I sleep so deeply I wouldn't notice if someone carried me away."

Ju Hwaran looked puzzled. Song Ilseom frowned as if I were talking nonsense. Leaving them to it, I burrowed deep into the straw piled in the carriage.

[2557] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2558] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Two shichen[2559] to Mount Daebyeol if we're quick. That's plenty of time.

It was time to have the dream I'd put off for so long.

Logout.

Ding.

With the clear chime of a bell, my alert consciousness slowly began to sink.

[2559] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Chapter 552

SYSTEM

Synchronization begins. 10, 9, 8, 7… 1, 0.
Synchronization completed successfully. Increased stats have been applied to the body, and use is restricted for certain Titles.
Logout complete.

Ding.

Before my blackened vision had even cleared, a cool breeze swept over my entire body, as it always did.

No—it washed through me, cleansing me.

Synchronization.

It was a process I had gone through every time I traveled between Murim and reality.

Changes to my stats took effect immediately, while scars and injuries didn't carry over. There was even a considerate feature that made changes to my physique and appearance happen gradually and naturally—probably because a sudden transformation would make people suspicious.

Fwoosh.

This time was no different.

Strength flowed into my body, which had already surpassed human limits, and I felt my muscles grow more supple. The internal energy refined through my battle with the Water God Dragon and Mungyeong's teachings changed with it.

"Phew."

The first thing I saw was a ceiling without a speck of dust on it. Several meters[2560] above me, it was covered by an old-fashioned painting.

Is it because I haven't seen it in a while? Or am I still not used to it?

I'd last been here before traveling along a tributary of the Yangtze toward Hubei Province. Roughly two months had passed before I returned.

Maybe that was why everything around me felt unfamiliar.

I lay under the soft blankets, staring at the ceiling for a long while. Then I asked, "What was the title of that painting again?"

A quiet answer came from nearby.

"The official title is the Sistine Chapel ceiling frescoes, but in Korea, it's better known as *The Creation—The Genesis*. It's a masterpiece created by Michelangelo Buonarroti, a sculptor and painter of the Renaissance."

[2560] One meter is about 3.28 ft; several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

"Ah, Michelangelo. Right."

"You've heard of him?"

"He's famous. Are you looking down on me because my school grades were Level 7?"[2561]

"What do your school grades have to do with it? You're much more famous than that painting now, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

Tap.

Soft leather slippers met the marble floor.

I turned my head on the pillow and saw a man crossing the vast—no, practically boundless—room.

How does he get more handsome every time I see him?

If he were merely good-looking, I might have been jealous. But once someone passed a certain point, all I could do was admire him. Especially when he had the presence to make those looks seem perfectly natural.

I grinned at the man I was seeing for the first time in two months.

"It's been a while, Team Leader Choi."

Team Leader Choi, handsome as ever in a silk robe, stopped in his tracks.

"You say that as though you've come back from somewhere far away."

"I dreamed about a pretty distant place. It was a long dream, too."

I'd spent more than two months in Murim, so it wasn't a lie. Considering everything that had happened, two months almost felt too short.

"It must not have been a bad dream."

"Not really. I had to fight a dragon right at the start."

"A Dragon?"

"Something a little different, but close."

"A nightmare, then. Better to wake up quickly from one of those."

Clink.

Team Leader Choi set the cup he was holding on the bedside table.

"Have some coffee."

"Is this made from some incredibly expensive beans?"

If it was coffee made from cat shit[2562]—or Hyuk Mujin's shit—like last time, I was going to refuse.

I glared suspiciously at the cup, but then my eyes widened as a familiar scent reached deep into my nose.

"Huh?"

[2561] Korean school-record grades use a nine-level scale, with Level 1 the highest and Level 9 the lowest.

[2562] Kopi luwak, or civet coffee, is an expensive coffee made from beans that have passed through the digestive tract of the Asian palm civet, a cat-like animal.

When I looked at him with an expression that said *surely not*, Team Leader Choi gave a quiet laugh.

"It's instant. Gold. Made strong."

"Damn, Team Leader Choi. You know what's good."

"At least I know you and coffee brewed from beans aren't a good match."

"Good. Ten points to Gryffindor."

I gave him a thumbs-up and downed the coffee in one gulp.

Mm. That's the stuff.

Cheap and sweet. Getting a taste of modern civilization again made me feel alive.

"Ah, that's good. I'm starting to wake up."

"Are you? You did sleep longer than usual today."

Like other Awakened and Murim martial artists, I had a body that had surpassed human limits. I needed even less sleep than most.

I rarely slept more than two hours a day, and even that was more to satisfy the desire to sleep than out of any real need.

Unless I've pushed my body too hard or worn myself out mentally, I'm fine.

So when someone like me slept like the dead for hours, people were bound to wonder why.

I yawned and stretched.

"Are you all right?" he asked.

"I get days like this sometimes. Maybe all the fatigue caught up with me at once."

I sat up groggily and reached out. The smartphone on the bedside table flew toward me through *Seizing an Object Through Empty Space* and snapped into my hand like a magnet.

Maybe it's because I haven't seen this in a while, but it feels really strange.

It was part of the disorientation I felt every time I returned to reality.

I tapped the screen awkwardly. The time appeared.

7:05 a.m.

Seven in the morning. I'd gone to bed not long after midnight, so I'd slept about seven hours…

"Hm?"

What was this? The date looked strange.

I stared at the smartphone screen. Then a thought flashed through my mind, and my eyes widened.

"Ah."

So much had happened that I'd forgotten what day it was—and why I'd waited until after midnight to return to my room.

Just as I remembered, Team Leader Choi spoke.

"I said this last night, but I suppose I should say it again."

Swish.

He held out his hand, his quiet voice following close behind.

"I look forward to working with you this year as well, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

January 1, 2047.

Right. It was the first day of a new year in the modern world. And…

"Happy birthday."

"…!"

It was also my twenty-eighth birthday.

Damn it. Already?

The number thirty loomed so close that my vision went dark. Then two people burst in from across the room, making a racket.

"Hey, Twenty-Eight! Mom says to come eat seaweed soup!"[2563]

"I hereby congratulate you on the day of your birth!"

I take it back. They weren't people. They were two monsters.

Jin Hayeon, my old enemy on the family register, whom I was seeing for the first time in a while—and the blond foreigner beside her, the Skeleton King.

I sighed at the sight of them.

The time difference between Murim and the modern world was enormous.

From what I'd learned, whenever I crossed into one world, time in the other slowed to a crawl. Ten days in Murim amounted to about an hour in the modern world. No wonder I sometimes felt out of step.

Especially this time. So much happened.

Both worlds had changed rapidly. One of the changes was the enormous mansion where I now lived.

Step. Step.

White marble gleamed beneath our feet, and old-fashioned paintings and statues filled the halls.

More than anything, though…

"Wow. This place is ridiculously huge."

Huge enough to leave me speechless. Even if I put together every place I'd stayed while traveling between the two worlds, the total would be nothing next to this mansion.

Its owner didn't seem to agree.

[2563] Seaweed soup is traditionally eaten in Korea on birthdays.

"As you said, Mr. Jin Taekyung, it is somewhat large. It also takes a lot of work to maintain."

"For a place that takes so much work, I don't see anyone else around. Right, old man?[2564]"

Hayeon, who'd been trailing behind us, had suddenly joined the conversation.

She wasn't talking to Team Leader Choi.

The foreigner with hair like molten gold and strangely gleaming golden eyes frowned. At a glance, he looked like the sort of man who'd be caught up in Hollywood dating scandals.

"Surely you don't mean me."

"I do."

"Hah."

The Skeleton King—given a human appearance by Magic Johnson's illusion magic—let out a short laugh.

"You seem to misunderstand. As I understand it, the term you used refers to a male relative of an older generation, or a middle-aged man."

"Yes."

"…"

The Skeleton King was silent for a moment before squeezing out his voice.

"What I mean is…"

"You said you're over thirty. That makes you an old man to me."

"I am over thirty, but…"

"Oh, I get it. You *are* an old man. You just don't want to be called one, right?"

"…!"

His golden eyes trembled. He stopped walking and glared at Hayeon.

"They say blood relatives resemble each other. You two really are siblings."

Hayeon and I answered together.

"I'm an only child."

"I'm an only child, old man."

Good heavens. Now there were two wicked humans.

That was written all over his face as he looked from one of us to the other. Finally, he shook his head in defeat.

"All right. All right, so stop it, both of you. And you, insolent human girl. If you ever call me an old man again…"

Step.

He never finished.

[2564] Hayeon calls him *ajeossi*, a Korean word for a middle-aged man or a male relative of an older generation, used much like "mister" or "uncle." It implies he is no longer young.

Hayeon had stopped walking. She was staring at him blankly.

“What did you say?”

“No. That isn’t what I meant. I misspoke.”

The Skeleton King scrambled to take it back, glancing at me. Team Leader Choi sighed as though he’d been expecting this to happen sooner or later.

“You’ve done it now. I’ll take him away, Mr. Jin Taekyung. Please calm your sister down, and be careful she doesn’t misunderstand.”

“…?”

What was he talking about?

I blinked at him.

“Why?”

“Pardon?”

“No, why? Why do I have to calm her down?”

“Why? Miss Hayeon was just insulted—”

Before he could finish, Hayeon spoke.

“‘Insolent human girl’? Is that something you say to a person, you long-nosed bastard?”

“…Huh?”

“…What?”

Here we go. I smiled warmly.

She hasn’t changed a bit.

Yes. This was Jin Hayeon.

As my capillaries swelled magnificently, I finally felt that I had truly returned to the modern world.

Hayeon whipped around to face me.

“Did you hear what that Yankee bastard just said?”

I nodded silently.

“I heard.”

“Does he have dirt on you? Did someone catch you doing a private webcam show? Why else would you hang around with a bastard like that? Someone who isn’t even human…”

That’s surprisingly accurate.

“Oh, right,” I said, impressed. “He really isn’t human.”

“He called me an insolent human girl. Does that psycho think that even counts as words?”

“Well, they are words. Just bad ones.”

“If he’d called me a crazy bitch or something normal, I wouldn’t even complain. But *human girl*? It feels so gross. Seriously.”

I took out my smartphone and whispered, “Siri, tell me today’s weather.”

“Today’s weather is clear.”

“You asshole. You think I’m in the mood for wordplay? Your one and only little sister just got called that by someone else!”

I hurriedly straightened my clothes and bowed politely.

“Hello. My name is Jin Taekyung, and I’m an only child.”

“You really are a lunatic.”

“That’s rather harsh for a first meeting. I’ll sue you for defamation by stating facts.”[2565]

Hayeon’s eyes turned cold.

“I’m telling Mom everything.”

“What?”

“I’m telling Mom. Every last thing.”

“Are you threatening me?”

“Yep.”

“You little…”

Wham!

Eyes bulging, I grabbed someone by the collar with all my strength.

Not Hayeon’s, of course. The Skeleton King’s.

“Apologize to my sister right now! You less-than-human bastard! You monster!”

“I-I’m sorry! I was wrong! I’ll apologize a hundred times, just please…!”

“Of course she’s insolent! And human! And a girl! But you can’t put all three together like that!”

“Ugh! Grrrgh!”

“Say it properly! Put the right words together!”

“I-Insolent! Person! Girl!”

Boom.

At least, I thought I heard something like that.

It was Hayeon’s anger gauge bursting. She picked up the nearest plaster statue.

“Die. Just die, both of you!”

Whoosh! Clang!

The hallway descended into chaos, beginning with the daily clang.

Hayeon charged at us like a brave Viking warrior, while Team Leader Choi stared at the scene unfolding before him in stunned disbelief.

That was when—

“I told you to come eat. What’s all this noise…!”

[2565] In South Korea, a true statement can still be grounds for a defamation claim if it harms someone’s reputation, subject to exceptions such as public interest.

The elevator at the far end of the hallway opened. A familiar face emerged and froze.

Dear Lady Kim Jeonghee.

My mother.

"…What are you doing, all of you?"

From her tiny body—not even 160 centimeters[2566] tall—I felt an aura to rival at least one of the Ten Kings.

[2566] 160 centimeters is about 5 ft 3 in.

Chapter 553

No matter how many levels I gained or how high I raised my stats, one fact would never change: to one person, I was still her immature little boy.

And… my mother, dear Lady Kim Jeonghee, had attack power that ignored every defense.

“What are you two doing?”

One hand was clenched into a fist. The other held a ladle. Sensing that things were getting serious, I spoke quickly.

“Lady Kim. You may have forgotten, but it’s your son’s birthday today.”

“So?”

“I’m almost thirty. Wouldn’t hitting me in front of other people be a little embarrassing?”

“I’ll be sixty before you know it.”

“Ah. Right…”

Wrong approach. I acknowledged my mistake deep in my heart and changed tack.

“Two months—no, not that long ago, I was fighting monsters for my life.”

“Thank goodness you came back safely, son.”

“Thank you, Mother.”

“Then why do you keep fighting with your little sister, who’s eight years younger than you, instead of a monster?”

“Mother. I don’t fight people. Therefore, that thing isn’t my little sister. It’s a monster.”

“Then you’re saying I gave birth to a monster.”

“…!”

“My palm or my ladle—which would you prefer?”

Checkmate. Realizing there was no escape, I closed my eyes and answered quietly.

“Your palm.”

“Forearm? Back?”

“I’ll take the back.”

I considered my answer carefully. The punishment came immediately.

“Mom told you—”

Smack!

“Not to fight!”

Smack!

“Didn’t I?”

Smack!

“Eek!”

"Ugh!"

Good heavens. Was that the Flame Divine Palm?

Pain bored into my back, and Hayeon and I screamed.

Even the perfect body known in Murim as the Heavenly Martial Physique was useless now. This fear—and this pain—were engraved on my soul.

I can't dodge, either.

If I did, she would apply the crime of insolence and trigger a tenfold event.

In the end, Hayeon and I weren't released until Mom had stamped her handprints on our backs. Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King stared at Lady Kim as she turned away, breathing hard. Their eyes were practically shaking.

"Y-Your mother. I was trying to stop them."

"I am American. Citizen of the United States. Do not touch me. Please."

Their desperate attempts to survive were almost pitiful.

Of course, Lady Kim gave them a warm smile as though nothing had happened.

"Oh, my children were making trouble, weren't they? I'm sorry. Neither of them has grown up yet. I'm making breakfast, so come eat with us."

"Th-Thank you."

"Thank you. Thank you, Jeonghee."

What the hell, you son of a bitch?

I could let the rest go, but the Skeleton King was dead for that "Thank you, Jeonghee."

I promised him murder with a look, then headed toward the dining room.

The mansion was enormous, so the distance to the dining room was considerable. But the elevator installed inside the house and the short-range Teleport magic circles made the journey quick.

"…?"

Wait. Now that I thought about it, this was ridiculous. Why was there a Teleport magic circle inside a mansion?

I stared at Team Leader Choi in disbelief. He answered calmly.

"The mansion is quite large. As I understand it, they were installed to reduce travel time."

"…Right. That's what Teleport magic circles are for. Obviously."

He might as well have said, *People eat to fill their stomachs.*

Then again, perhaps all of this really was normal to Team Leader Choi.

He certainly didn't grow up in an ordinary family.

Even a third-generation Korean chaebol[2567] heir or the youngest son of a famed swordsmanship family would have to defer to him. His maternal grandfather was

[2567] A chaebol is a large, family-controlled South Korean business conglomerate.

the immortal hero who had defeated the Demon King Asmodeus in the final battle and saved humanity.

Cheon Taemin.

If the birth of a prophet had divided an era into before and after, Cheon Taemin had decided the fate of humanity.

Tens of millions had seen him. Hundreds of millions remembered him. The vast records of his existence would remain through countless ages, until the day humanity itself came to an end.

And that very Cheon Taemin once lived in this mansion.

Even Team Leader Choi, his maternal grandson, did not know where he was or whether he was alive. But putting that aside, the thought was moving in its own way.

I was only staying here temporarily because the press wouldn't leave me alone, but it felt as though I was sharing a space with the immortal hero Cheon Taemin.

This is incredible.

I looked around the mansion, where immensely valuable A-rank Magic Gems had been slotted in like batteries to provide a constant supply of energy, and drew in a deep breath.

"Hoooh."

Team Leader Choi gave me an uneasy look.

"…What are you doing?"

"Should I say I'm absorbing the energy? Or that I'm sensing the scent of a hero?"

Hayeon rubbed her sore back and muttered, "He's just a pervert. He has a smell fetish."

"Would you be quiet, insolent human girl?"

"Oh, really? Mom—mmph!"

"If you don't want to get murdered tonight, keep your mouth shut."

I was almost thirty. I didn't want to get hit in front of other people again.

Fortunately, someone appeared just before Lady Kim, sensing that something was amiss, turned around.

"Good morning."

A smooth, low voice that sounded like a coffee commercial had started playing. Even at this early hour, his pompadour was immaculate, and his tailored suit was neat and dignified.

Butler Kim approached at an unhurried pace and bowed first to Team Leader Choi.

"Did you sleep well, Young Master?"

Team Leader Choi nodded as though this were perfectly ordinary.

"Yes. I went to bed a little late because I had a few things to take care of, but I'm feeling fine."

"The proposal from Mr. Johnson, I presume."

"A few terms in our agreement with the Wizard Guild need adjusting. I've put the details together, so…"

Hayeon, listening to them, muttered, "Is this a scene from a TV drama or what?"

"Not a drama. If anything, it's a web novel."

A webtoon, maybe. Turning this kind of fantasy into a TV drama would cost a fortune.

"Just let it go. You'll get used to it if you watch long enough."

"To *that?*"

"…At least try."

Honestly, it still threw me every time.

Barely six months ago in modern-world time, I'd been an F-rank Hunter getting by on blood sausage gukbap[2568] and cup noodles. Now the media hailed me as the new hero following in Cheon Taemin's footsteps, and an S-rank Hunter license made from specially processed top-grade Magic Gems sat in the old leather wallet I still hadn't replaced.

I should be getting used to this by now, but somehow it isn't happening.

Maybe I still had too much to do. Keeping up with one crisis after another while rushing between the modern world and Murim was hard enough. Perhaps it would be stranger if I could settle in and enjoy the wealth and fame I'd been given.

"We can discuss the details after breakfast, Young Master."

"Ah, yes. Let's do that."

Their brief conversation ended, and I followed Team Leader Choi and Butler Kim into the dining room.

No, *dining room* didn't do it justice. *Banquet hall* was closer.

It was enormous, spotless, and elegant. Robots equipped with advanced AI waited at their assigned positions.

Yet in this room, where every detail had been prepared with meticulous care, one thing wasn't ready.

"Hmm."

"Just as I thought."

Everyone except Hayeon and me blinked. The Skeleton King sounded genuinely confused when he whispered to me.

"Wicked human. May I ask you something?"

"Go ahead."

[2568] Gukbap is a Korean dish of rice served in hot soup.

“We were told to eat. Why, then, is there nothing on the table?”

The enormous table in the center of the banquet hall was completely empty. No dishes, no food—nothing but a perfect blank slate.

I had already guessed the reason, so I quietly nodded.

“That’s how it works.”

“What?”

“An absolute rule. Or a species-wide habit. Something like that.”

When Mom called us to eat, it meant she was still making the food. Whether she called once or ten times, yelling that everything was ready and we needed to come out right now, the result was the same when we got there.

Hayeon knew it too. She was already looking for the utensils.

“Sorry, where do you keep the spoons and chopsticks?”

“Pardon?”

“Spoons and chopsticks.”

Team Leader Choi blinked, then turned slowly toward Butler Kim.

“Butler Kim?”

At that moment, a single stray hair stuck out from Butler Kim’s perfectly arranged pompadour.

“Those functions are all integrated into the robots’ circuits, so they should bring everything automatically… But why aren’t the robots moving?”

Just then, Lady Kim peeked her head out from the kitchen. She had rushed there earlier with a ladle in hand, saying that the soup was boiling.

“Oh, I turned them all off.”

“What?”

“Pardon?”

“I already feel bad imposing on you. It seemed a waste of electricity. The kids can set things out in no time, so please, have a seat.”

“…”

“…”

There was no way Lady Kim would hear that every robot in the mansion ran on embedded Magic Gems rather than electricity, or that there was no need to save money on the electric bill.

She was a veteran homemaker who had spent her life scrimping and scraping to raise two children.

As everyone stared at me, speechless, I merely smacked my lips.

“Just accept it. I’ve tried explaining it more than once or twice, but it never gets through.”

She’d even saved every bit of the money I sent home, saying she couldn’t possibly spend it.

Remembering her old days working in a restaurant kitchen, I smiled bitterly, then smacked the Skeleton King on the back of the head.

Whack!

“Why me…?”

“What are you doing, asshole? Go help.”

“Wicked human. This is unfair. And un-American!”

“Then go to America. The moment you arrive, they’ll find out you’re a monster and drag you off to the Octagon.”

Team Leader Choi stared at me in bewilderment.

“It’s the Pentagon, Mr. Jin Taekyung…”

“Octagon, Pentagon—whatever. You and Butler Kim go help too.”

“Pardon?”

“We’re eating together. We should all help get it ready.”

Team Leader Choi’s gaze wavered.

“Eating… together?”

“You heard me. Go set out the utensils. I’ll be watching to make sure you do it properly.”

His gaze steadied again.

“Watching?”

“Yes.”

“And what about you, Mr. Jin Taekyung? Aren’t you doing anything?”

“It’s my birthday. Even at the Hunter training camp, they gave people free time on their birthdays.”

“…”

“What are you waiting for? We need to be ready before the seaweed soup[2569] comes out.”

His parents had died, his grandfather Cheon Taemin had disappeared, and Lee Jungryong had shut him out afterward. But Team Leader Choi was still the Young Master of a wealthy household.

This must have been something he had never experienced in his life.

I let out a quiet laugh as he walked away with Butler Kim, wearing a dazed expression I’d never seen on him before. Then I sat down and pulled out my smartphone.

Nothing beats the news when you need to figure out what’s going on.

Tap. Tap-tap.

A few touches took me to a large online community open only to Hunters. I found an article posted just ten minutes earlier, and my hand stopped.

[2569] In Korea, seaweed soup is traditionally eaten on birthdays.

> Former Ares Guild Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong, 68: National funeral scheduled for tomorrow.
>
> Where is the immortal hero Cheon Taemin?
>
> Amid global attention, Ares Guild members remaining in Sichuan Province depart the country. Interest from around the world turns to Hunter Go Jun, the late Lee Jungryong's Head of Security…

"Go Jun."

Right. That guy was still around.

Chapter 554

The monster wave in Sichuan Province, dubbed the Small Cataclysm, had devoured so much.

Buildings, people, hope… More than four million people were dead or injured, and property damage ran into the hundreds of trillions of won.[2570]

But as someone once said, people leave their names behind when they die. Among the countless dead, a few names stood out.

[Search Efforts Exhausted, but the Hero's Remains Were Never Found]

[Who Was the Late Lee Jungryong?]

[The Immortal Hero Cheon Taemin Always Had One Person at His Side]

[Wu Heixing and Lee Jungryong: Their Deaths Were the Same, but Their Nobility Was Not]

[Late Lee Jungryong to Receive National Funeral… Waves of Mourning Pour In from Around the World]

Every article occupying the top of the major forum sites contained the same person's name.

Lee Jungryong. Another hero of the Great Cataclysm, who had wielded full authority over the Ares Guild in place of the vanished Cheon Taemin.

No. A hero of the past now, I suppose.

Lee Jungryong was dead.

The world had been told that the Lich killed him, but I was the one who had ended his life.

Yes. That day.

I had broken Wu Heixing's neck while he begged me to spare him, then driven the blade of my spear into Lee Jungryong's chest and reduced him to ash.

There had been no other choice. I'd gone with them all the way to the Lich's stronghold despite suspecting they might stab me in the back. That was the last chance I'd given them.

Last meant there wouldn't be another.

Even if it hadn't happened then, I would have killed him eventually.

If Wu Heixing had been like a fish bone stuck in my throat, Lee Jungryong had been a blade digging into it.

He was as strong as a beast of prey and as cunning as a fox. When I first met him, he had seemed like a wall I could never overcome. I'd brought him down only because I'd grown far faster than he thought possible.

If Lee Jungryong had been a little bolder, things might have turned out differently…

[2570] "Hundreds of trillions of won" is roughly 200–900 trillion won: about $140–640 billion and €130–580 billion.

But he had misjudged me, and here was the result: me, reading about his death on my smartphone on the first day of the new year.

His final words flashed through my mind.

"I… have no regrets. None."

Lee Jungryong had been smiling when he said them.

His entire body was drenched in blood and battered beyond recognition, yet as he smiled brightly, his eyes burned with the obsession and fury he had refused to let go of until the very end.

As if this wasn't over. As if he'd become a vengeful spirit and haunt me even after death.

Well, he couldn't haunt me now that he was dead. But on one point, I agreed with him: it wasn't over.

There was still someone in this world who was practically another Lee Jungryong.

Go Jun.

Lee Jungryong's blindly devoted Head of Security. No—his Disciple.

I stared down at my smartphone and tapped an article.

Tap.

An image filled the screen at once. It showed Ares Guild members departing Sichuan Province, with Go Jun among them, his face set and rigid.

[Ares Guild Heads Home for the Funeral of the Late Lee Jungryong]

[Who Is Go Jun, Head of Security for the Late Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong?]

I read the bold headlines and scrolled down to the long stream of comments.

> ㄴ May the deceased rest in peace.
>
> ㄴ Lee Jungryong is dead… Another great star has fallen.
>
> ㄴ I don't know whether Jun Dragon[2571] was a good person. I heard some pretty suspicious stories about him, too.
>
> ㄴ I agree, but those stories are still unverified rumors. And you think a dinosaur of a Guild like Ares could operate without getting a little dirty? Just shut up, press X, and pay your respects.[2572] Considering what Lee Jungryong did during the Great Cataclysm, it's the least you can do.
>
> ㄴ But who's Go Jun? They say he was Lee Jungryong's Head of Security, but I've never seen him before.
>
> ㄴ People who know, know. You're either not a Hunter or you're still new.

[2571] An online nickname for Lee Jungryong that plays on *ryong*, meaning "dragon."

[2572] A variation on the video-game prompt "Press F to pay respects," commonly quoted online.

> ㄴ How did you know? I spent all my time stuck in a study room, then awakened by accident. Now I don't know anything. If you know something, tell me.
>
> ㄴ Actually, I don't know either. This is my older brother's account.
>
> ㄴ You fucking bastard.
>
> ㄴ Waaah. I'm a baby fucking bastard.
>
> ㄴ What a shitshow up there. Hunters with some standing or experience probably know him, though. Go Jun is famous as Jun Dragon's[2573] right-hand man. He appeared out of nowhere about ten years ago and caused quite a stir. After that, Jun Dragon[2574] always brought him to official events.
>
> ㄴ Seriously. I just searched iTube,[2575] and he was standing behind Lee Jungryong at last year's UN General Assembly. That was from a quick search. If someone really dug, they'd probably find tons more.
>
> ㄴ Think Lee Jungryong raised him as a Disciple?
>
> ㄴ King-sized possibility. Other communities are already digging into Go Jun's background. Apparently, he came from a children's home—orphanage?—that Lee Jungryong sponsored. He's never taken the ranker test, but they say he's stronger than the highest-ranked rankers.
>
> ㄴ So is he Ares Guild's next Vice Guild Master?
>
> ㄴ No one knows, but he's probably the front-runner. Unless Cheon Taemin shows up, Go Jun will likely take over without much trouble. Strength plus legitimacy. That's a pure enough bloodline to make Voldemort shed a tear.
>
> ㄴ Agreed. He looks like a Death Eater, too. Probably a Slytherin.
>
> ㄴ Keep attacking his looks and Ares Guild might attack you.
>
> ㄴ Speaking of pure bloodlines, I heard something weird recently.
>
> ㄴ ?
>
> ㄴ ??
>
> ㄴ What?
>
> ㄴ I'm too scared to say exactly who, but you know. Someone in the P— Guild is Cheon Taemin's—no, not Cheon Taemin. I'm deleting this myself. Please don't bring it up.
>
> ㄴ Ah, fuck.
>
> ㄴ There are two ways to make someone angry. The first is to start saying something and then stop.
>
> ㄴ Ha… Some bastard just cost me a night's sleep.

[2573] An online nickname for Lee Jungryong that plays on *ryong*, meaning "dragon."
[2574] An online nickname for Lee Jungryong that plays on *ryong*, meaning "dragon."
[2575] A fictional video and live-streaming platform.

Clink.

The sudden noise drew my eyes from the phone.

Team Leader Choi had set the tableware down beside me. He looked faintly displeased.

“What are you reading so intently?”

“Something about you in the article comments, Team Leader Choi.”

“Pardon?”

“It’d be quicker to show you. Just a moment.”

I looked back at my phone and smacked my lips. The comment had been deleted in the brief time I’d looked away.

He said he was scared and would delete it. He really did delete it and run.

“What comment?”

“It’s gone now. But it was definitely about you.”

“If it was about me… was it related to my maternal grandfather?”

I gave a small nod.

I wasn’t the only one who’d drawn attention during the Small Cataclysm in Sichuan Province. While the world was in an uproar over the monster wave caused by the Lich, the media and the public had barely stopped talking about me. But at some point, word of Team Leader Choi had begun to spread as well.

A needle in a bag.[2576]

That was Team Leader Choi. He’d learned martial arts from me and taken his skills to another level, then distinguished himself on the battlefield. He was also handsome enough to put a celebrity to shame. The attention from people who cared about looks alone was nothing to sneeze at.

And he was Cheon Taemin’s only living blood relative.

But Lee Jungryong had kept Team Leader Choi’s existence under wraps while he was alive. Team Leader Choi had done the same.

Until then, the two of them had been a dinosaur and an ant. Even if revealing his identity turned him into a golden ant, he would still be an ant.

Now Lee Jungryong was dead, and the truth they’d hidden—whether by choice or circumstance—was slowly coming to light.

What bothered me was how natural it all seemed. How perfectly timed.

I gazed steadily at Team Leader Choi.

“This was what you intended, wasn’t it, Team Leader Choi?”

“To be honest, yes. I judged that now was the right time.”

“Wow. I didn’t expect you to admit it. Have you always been this honest?”

[2576] A Korean idiom meaning that exceptional talent will eventually reveal itself, even when hidden.

“What else do I have to hide from you, Mr. Jin Taekyung? Of course, even if I’m honest with you, you still have plenty of secrets.”

“…You didn’t have to put it like that.”

A twinge of guilt caught me off guard.

I already knew Team Leader Choi suspected there was more to me than he’d been told. Since getting the System, I’d spent more time with him than with anyone else in the modern world, and I’d heard him say as much himself.

Still, when he came right out with it, I had no answer.

I scratched my chin awkwardly.

“Putting that aside, can I ask you a few things?”

“Go ahead. The seaweed soup[2577] will be out soon, so you’ll have to be quick.”

“If this was your plan, wouldn’t it have been better for me to tell everyone what Lee Jungryong was really like?”

Lee Jungryong’s and Wu Heixing’s deaths had been blamed on the Lich. The truth had been buried, which was why people were mourning them with some goodwill.

Wu Heixing had always been a rotten bastard, and the atrocities involving his family had come to light, so people were still cursing him after his death. Lee Jungryong, on the other hand, was being mourned as a fallen great star.

They were giving him a national funeral. That said it all.

If the truth had come out, things would have been different. I might not have had hard evidence, but I’d earned enough Fame as a new hero that people couldn’t simply dismiss my testimony as nonsense.

Lee Jungryong’s reputation would have been ruined, and Team Leader Choi’s plan would have gone smoothly.

“But you told me not to tell the media what Lee Jungryong had done.”

Team Leader Choi nodded calmly.

“Yes, I did.”

“Why?”

His answer came without a moment’s hesitation.

“Because I didn’t want to dirty what’s mine.”

“What?”

“Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong was certainly a man with an ugly side. He helped my maternal grandfather and made major contributions during the Great Cataclysm, but he gradually became corrupted. He took full control of the Ares Guild and committed all kinds of crimes. The important thing is…”

Team Leader Choi went on in a dry voice.

“The blame wouldn’t fall on Lee Jungryong alone. It would fall on the entire Ares Guild.”

[2577] In Korea, seaweed soup is traditionally eaten on birthdays.

"…!"

"The Ares Guild's influence is immense. My maternal grandfather has been out of sight for years, and Lee Jungryong is dead, but people still have absolute faith in its power."

Clink.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

Team Leader Choi ran his fingers over the perfectly clean tableware, his eyes sinking into deep stillness.

"I don't want food splashed with filth. Even if there's hair in it and it's crawling with maggots, it must look better than anything else on the outside. I want it in my hands with all its influence intact."

I'd overlooked the power of the Ares name. Its influence.

And Team Leader Choi wanted the Ares Guild whole, without a blemish on its surface. He wanted all that power and influence for himself.

Removing the hair Lee Jungryong had planted and picking out the vermin would come afterward.

"I've waited a long time for this."

Team Leader Choi murmured the words, his eyes glinting coldly.

Chapter 555

He was built like an iron tower. His expression was as hard and unchanging as stone, his lips pressed tightly together.

And then… there were his eyes.

Bloodshot eyes filled with rage, grief, and emotions too tangled to name. Meeting his gaze alone was enough to send a chill down anyone's spine.

Even the Prime Minister of Korea—a permanent member of the UN Security Council and one of the world's great powers—was no exception.

What the hell is with that look…?

The gaze struck him like a blade the moment he entered the room. The Prime Minister flinched, then forced his pounding heart to settle.

The man before him might be one of Korea's most formidable Hunters, but he himself had spent sixty years of life in the mud of politics. There was no reason to be intimidated before they had even begun to talk.

Especially not now.

Having recovered some of his composure, the Prime Minister held out his hand.

"Oh, there you are, Mr. Go Jun."

Go Jun stared at the offered hand. Instead of shaking it, he answered in a dry voice.

"It's been a while, Prime Minister Jang."

That was no way to treat either a man considerably older than himself or the prime minister of his country. Wrinkles bunched across Prime Minister Jang's forehead.

"…Ha. You must be grieving more deeply than I realized. I understand how you feel."

"Understand?"

Go Jun's eyes grew redder. No one could understand what he was feeling.

Yet this sly old raccoon had the nerve to smile and say that.

Crack.

The bones in his clenched fist shifted with an audible snap.

Go Jun had once been so quiet and sparing with his emotions that he seemed carved from stone. The death of Lee Jungryong, the man he had respected and followed more than anyone, had changed him unmistakably.

"Ahem."

Prime Minister Jang was not too oblivious to notice. He glanced uneasily at Go Jun's fist and lowered himself awkwardly into a chair.

"I seem to have misspoken. If I offended you, I apologize."

"…It's fine. I let my emotions get the better of me as well."

Go Jun forced down his boiling anger.

He was no longer the orphan of thirty-odd years ago, with nothing left to lose. He had what his Master had passed down to protect, and a mountain of work to do if he meant to protect it.

“But did you really come alone, Prime Minister?”

There it was. Prime Minister Jang answered the abrupt question as calmly as he could.

“I did.”

“Then where is the President?”

“I imagine you already know where he is.”

Prime Minister Jang glanced toward the covered window. Specially treated blackout curtains hid the view, but drawing them back would reveal the Blue House[2578] directly beyond.

“The President has pressing matters to attend to. He’ll come when the national funeral officially begins in three hours. I believe his office already informed you…?”

As Prime Minister Jang’s words trailed off, Go Jun’s gaze darkened.

“That’s why I asked again. I couldn’t believe what I’d been told.”

“What?”

“Prime Minister Jang. No…”

Go Jun leaned forward from the sofa. The old politician’s reflection appeared in his red eyes, and a chilling voice passed his lips.

“Mr. Jang Taekhwan.”

“…!”

“Stop screwing around and let’s speak frankly. Go back and arrange a private meeting with the President right now. There are still three hours before the national funeral proceedings begin, so I’ll give you one hour.”

“H-Hey! How dare you—”

“How dare I?”

Crsh.

Prime Minister Jang’s eyes widened. The sturdy crystal glass in Go Jun’s hand was crumbling into fine powder, spilling between his fingers.

At the same time, the change in Go Jun’s tone cut into the Prime Minister’s ears.

“That’s right. How dare you act like this. Have you forgotten who paved the easy road you’ve walked all these years?”

“Y-You…”

The old politician’s voice shook.

[2578] The Blue House is the name of South Korea’s presidential office and residence.

Go Jun was telling the truth. The name Ares Guild was an indelible stain on Prime Minister Jang's decades in politics.

They were the ones who had cleaned up the filth he left behind, wiped his ass, and loaded heavy boxes into his car trunk.

But…

"That—that was Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong! Not you!"

"That's right. It was all the Vice Guild Master's doing. No—my Master's."

A dry smile touched Go Jun's lips.

"And now it's my job."

"…!"

"Don't get the wrong idea. He may be dead, but the Ares Guild still stands."

The Ares Guild was an impregnable fortress.

Cheon Taemin, the immortal hero and savior of humanity, had laid its cornerstone. Lee Jungryong had built walls no one dared challenge.

"There isn't a place in Yeouido[2579]—or anywhere in this country—beyond our reach."

This was a world ruled by the laws of capitalism.

None of the world's ten largest Guilds appeared in Forbes's annual rankings of major corporations. Everyone knew how much power and wealth those Guilds held anyway, and how much influence the Ares Guild held even among them.

Now that power would pass from the dead to the living.

"Do you think all he left me was his dying wish?"

"W-What?"

Prime Minister Jang's eyes widened. According to the NIS,[2580] Lee Jungryong had left no will.

No—there was not supposed to be a will.

The ignorant public had been talking about it endlessly, but the Prime Minister had firmly believed the information he had received.

"Then you…"

Go Jun's eyes flashed red.

"You should call me Vice Guild Master, not 'you.'"

"…!"

A faint tremor ran through the old politician's body. After a suffocating silence, he spoke weakly.

"Mr. Go Jun. No, Vice Guild Master Go. The situation isn't as simple as you think."

[2579] Yeouido is a district of Seoul that houses South Korea's National Assembly and major financial institutions.

[2580] The NIS is South Korea's National Intelligence Service.

The red light in Go Jun's eyes gradually faded. His voice remained dry, but his tone softened somewhat.

"I know. That's why you'll have to work harder, Prime Minister Jang. You and the others."

"Whew. That's… not easy. There are rumors, too."

"Rumors?"

"Hunter Jin Taekyung. No—I'm not trying to talk about him. Of course, he is connected to this to a considerable degree."

Prime Minister Jang had hurried to explain himself when Go Jun reacted to the name. He continued.

"You already know about the young Team Leader from the Peace Guild, don't you? His name is Choi Minwoo, I believe."

"…Go on."

"Since Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong passed away, people around us have had plenty to say. Even with someone to succeed him… it's true that the Ares Guild isn't what it used to be."

Lee Jungryong had been a symbol in his own right.

He was a hero who had suppressed the Great Cataclysm at Cheon Taemin's side, as well as an S-rank Hunter counted among the very best in the entire world.

His death would not bring the Ares Guild down overnight. But its strength and influence were bound to diminish sharply.

Damn it.

Go Jun knew that. Better than anyone.

The grumbling and resistance already rising throughout the Guild were proof. So was Prime Minister Jang's attitude—something he would never have dared while Lee Jungryong was alive.

If Master were here. If he were still alive…

The words lingered on Go Jun's tongue, but he did not let them out.

He could not afford to show any more uncertainty. His face hardened as he spoke.

"You seem to have plenty of worries, Prime Minister Jang. And plenty of time."

"What does that—"

"The Ares Guild will handle its own affairs. You should handle yours."

"No, that's not what I—"

Go Jun watched him try to explain, then leaned back against the sofa.

"Fifty minutes."

"F-Fifty minutes? What do you mean?"

"Ten minutes have passed since I gave you an hour. That leaves fifty. I don't think you have time to sit here any longer. Am I wrong?"

"…!"

It was a clear dismissal: arrange the private meeting with the President, whatever it took, before the national funeral began.

Prime Minister Jang rose on unsteady legs and turned toward the door. Go Jun's quiet voice reached him from behind.

"One more thing. That person… the Guild Master won't be coming. Keep everyone in line so there's no gossip."

What more could he say?

Prime Minister Jang nodded weakly and left the private room.

Click.

The door sounded unusually loud as it shut. Go Jun stared at the empty place where the Prime Minister had been, then glanced down at his left arm.

Two black stripes marked his mourning armband. With no suitable blood relative to take the role for Lee Jungryong, Go Jun had become the chief mourner.

Master. Are you at peace there?

He could not remember his parents' faces, yet he missed the face of Lee Jungryong—a man who shared none of his blood—with a pain that cut deep.

He would probably never forget his Master. Nor would he forget the two names that followed him like tags.

"…Jin Taekyung. Choi Minwoo."

The man who had killed his Master. And the man who meant to take everything his Master had built.

His voice came hot through clenched teeth, and his eyes burned redder than ever.

Still trembling with rage, Go Jun suddenly felt at his neck.

Clink.

Cold metal met his fingertips. He unclasped the necklace and stared down at it. Its plating had worn away in patches, leaving it ugly and battered.

Master.

He knew this necklace was not Lee Jungryong. It was not even something Lee Jungryong had left behind.

But one thing was certain.

It was the only thing that had kept its shape in the ruins of what had once been the Arch Lich's stronghold.

It was a mere trinket. To Go Jun, it had been worth paying the head of the investigation team a fortune in bribes to smuggle it out.

"…Whew."

Go Jun let out a deep sigh and rose from his seat.

He was the chief mourner at this grand funeral. He had to greet the countless people waiting outside and show his face to media from around the world, making clear who now wielded power in the Ares Guild.

Click.

When he opened the door, dozens of men and women lined up along the corridor bowed their heads.

Their eyes were fierce, and even their smallest movements carried force. Each one looked every bit the A-rank Hunter they were.

They were Go Jun's new hands and feet.

"Let's go."

At his quiet command, dozens of footsteps crossed the corridor.

The national funeral for Lee Jungryong, former Vice Guild Master of the Ares Guild, lasted five days and was held on a grand scale.

Media and powerful figures from around the world came to Korea. Hundreds of thousands of citizens took to the streets to mourn while the funeral was under way.

But not everyone did. To people hungry today, someone else's death could feel very far away.

Slash!

Stab-stab-stab!

"Kill it! Stab it now!"

"Keep your distance! Hey, you bastard! Don't rush out!"

—Kieeeek!

Shrill cries rang through a damp, dark cave.

Weapons deliberately smeared with mud to dull their shine moved without pause, seeking to end their enemies' lives.

Whoosh—thud!

"Seongha!"

"You monster bastards!"

—Kik. Kiririik!

The battle between Hunters and monsters was fierce, and desperate besides.

Then, as the two species' differently colored blood sprayed in every direction—

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The ground shook. Stalactites fell from the cave ceiling.

At the same moment, a surge of powerful magical power swept through the Gate from somewhere. The humans screamed.

"A Mutated Gate!"

"Fuck…"

That much magical power could not come from a low-level Gate. Mid-level at the very least. No, high-level.

Perhaps higher still.

Th-This is…

It's over.

Death. Just as despair settled over every face at the thought of it, someone's sighing voice echoed through the dark cave.

"Fuck. Brings back old memories."

Chapter 556

Whew.

I looked around with a sigh.

A damp, chilly cave. Narrow passages tangled together like a maze. Sharp stalactites hanging from the ceiling. Exhausted faces, frightened out of their minds.

Just like back then.

Three years ago. No—if I counted the time I'd spent in Murim, it had been four.

The accident that day remained seared into my heart like an indelible brand, and even now, after taking my revenge, I still couldn't completely forget it.

"Fuck. Brings back old memories."

Unlike me, muttering gruffly, the Skeleton King smiled fondly.

"I feel the same. It is as though I have returned to what you humans call home."

"…"

That's not what I meant, man.

We seemed to be remembering entirely different things. For all I knew, this guy might have been Skeleton One, some skeleton I'd run into back when I was going from one low-level Gate to the next.

Anyway…

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

That wave of magical power is much stronger than I expected.

It was lucky we had been nearby. Otherwise, twenty hardworking living people would almost have been wiped out.

I beckoned to the Hunters staring blankly at us.

"It's dangerous. Come over here."

A man in his late twenties who looked like the Team Leader blinked.

"W-What?"

"I said come over here. Hurry."

"W-Who are you?"

The cave was dark, and they were standing a considerable distance away. Their level was far too low for them to make out my face from that far.

I scratched my chin awkwardly. "I'm… Uh, look behind you."

"What?"

Their reaction was slow. Instead of answering, I snapped my fingers.

Whoosh—boom!

A faint whistle cut through the air, and green blood splattered everywhere. Behind one of the Hunters, a rusty ax slipped from the hand of a goblin that had been creeping up on him.

Then its headless body collapsed like a rotten log.

Thud!

“Gah!”

“Behind you! Watch your backs!”

“What the hell is this?”

What else? Finger Qi.

I muttered inwardly as I watched the Hunters hurriedly reform their ranks, then realized something.

It’ll be faster if I go to them than if they come to me.

They were struggling against goblins before they’d even made it halfway through the Gate. Being low-level Hunters was one thing, but they couldn’t have much experience, either.

The Skeleton King swept back his blond hair and put on a solemn expression.

“Hmph. It seems the time has come for this body to take the field.”

“Stay put. Don’t get cocky.”

“…”

I knew what needed doing, so there was no reason to hesitate. I headed toward them, neither hurrying nor taking my time.

Step.

One step. At the same time, ten streams of Finger Qi shot from my outstretched hands and tore through the air.

Whoosh—thud-thud-thud-thud!

Once more.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

And again.

Boom!

It took only a moment for nearly thirty goblins to end up sprawled across the ground as headless corpses. The last to fall was a hobgoblin that looked like their leader.

And then…

Step.

With my third and final step, a sphere of light summoned by an unknown mage’s Light magic shone on my face.

Flash.

“…!”

"…!"

An invisible shock wave and wave of agitation swept through the cave.

For a moment, everyone stared at my face in a daze. Then cries burst out from all around, like water breaking through a dam.

"L-Lord Fuck!"

"Lord Sibu-leol!"

"J-J-Jin Taekyung!"

The last one was better, at least.

The stutter had stretched my name to six syllables, but compared to those nicknames, it was practically respectable. Vice-minister[2581] respectable.

Come to think of it, the name fit the situation. The vibrations had grown steadily stronger, and now the whole cave was sh-sh-sh-shaking like a fucking earthquake.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The Skeleton King sauntered over, dodged a falling stalactite, and muttered, "This much commotion does not bode well."

"Tell me about it."

The magical power I was feeling was as far beyond what belonged in this E-rank Gate—or F-rank, even—as the Nanman Beast Palace was from Henan.

I clicked my tongue and beckoned to the still-stunned Hunters.

"Like I said, it's dangerous, so come over—"

Patter-patter-patter-patter!

"Whoa. You startled me."

"Undead, have mercy."

What was that, a Blink spell?

Being famous did have its advantages. Some old lady named Kim in the middle of nowhere had probably heard of me. Of course Hunters in the same line of work would know who I was.

Before I could finish speaking, all twenty of them came running at the speed of light. They looked at me with fear and trust in their eyes.

"Hyung.[2582] I'm a fan. A real fan."

"Eek! What do I do? What do I dooo?"

"…Thanks, but are you all out of your minds?"

How were they thinking about that at a time like this? I shook my head in disbelief and looked for the Team Leader.

At least he seemed to understand how serious things were. His face was stiff as he rummaged through his pocket and held something out to me.

[2581] A vice-minister served beneath a minister in a government department of Korea's Joseon dynasty.

[2582] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or older male acquaintance.

“Could I get your autograph? Please write, ‘Go, Hunter Lee Seungyeop!‘”

“…”

“Please. I’ll make it a family heirloom and pass it down for generations.”

“…”

Ah, fuck. I had no words.

Feeling miserable, I scrawled my signature across the briefing board. The Team Leader cautiously added, “And if it wouldn’t be too much trouble, could you swear once?”

“What?”

“Swear at me. It’s my wish.”

“…You fucking bastard.”

“Thank you! Thank you!”

“I meant it.”

“Gasp.”

One person—or rather, one monster—watched the exchange with obvious envy.

“You are rather popular, wretched human. They say that if one defecates, one becomes famous and people applaud.”

“…”

He had that backward somehow. Taking a shit in public might make you famous, but wouldn’t people slap you instead of applauding?

I didn’t have time to correct the Skeleton King’s distorted understanding. Just as I opened my mouth, the cave, already shaking like an earthquake had struck, lurched violently.

Rumble-rumble—crack!

The ground split, and cracks spread across the ceiling like a spiderweb. One of the Hunters groaned, “Is it collapsing…?”

Half right. Half wrong.

While everyone stared at the ceiling, which looked ready to come crashing down at any moment, I was the only one who knew what was happening below as well.

Crack. Crack-crack.

A sprout pushed its way through the solid rock covering the ground.

Dark red. Even as I watched, it grew at a frightening pace.

It produced thorns. A flower bud burst open, scattering seeds that soon began spreading in every direction.

Crack-crack-crack-crack!

“W-What is that?”

“Eeeeeek!”

“Ugh!”

“Cut it! Chop it down!”

The Hunters finally noticed and sprang into action. But screaming and hacking at the undergrowth did nothing to stop it from spreading.

Because this wasn’t happening only here.

Even if the Skeleton King and I stepped in, we couldn’t make it through the entire Gate and deal with all of it in so little time.

This is…

Not a simple collapse. A change.

The entire Gate was taking on a new form.

Mutation. Literally.

Before everyone’s horrified eyes, the Mutated Gate neared the end of its transformation.

Rumble-rumble-rumble. Boom!

The hairline cracks spreading across the ceiling darkened, and the gaps opened wide. It looked as though a giant egg—the cave itself—was breaking open.

And then…

Crack!

Beyond the ceiling, where nothing should have existed, something appeared, wreathed in red light and dim mist.

A vast space that dwarfed the cave. Dense vegetation. Heat as muggy as a wet sauna.

“What is that?”

“A-A jungle?”

Everyone was struck speechless. The Skeleton King whispered so that only I could hear.

“Wretched human. This body’s power is growing stronger.”

Illusion magic hid his true appearance, but the Skeleton King was a monster. If his power was growing stronger, it meant one thing.

The amount and density of the magical power.

I couldn’t see it. But I could feel it.

Whoosh…

Immense magical power filled the air. It had swelled almost to bursting, pressing down on the jungle.

It was a level of magical power that would be difficult to sense even in an A-rank Gate. There was no chance ordinary low-level Hunters could withstand it.

“Hhk. Hhk.”

“I-I can’t… breathe…”

Their pupils gradually lost focus, and they staggered. Not one of the twenty Hunters was spared. As they began passing out one by one, the Skeleton King frowned at me for standing by and watching.

"Wretched human. You…"

"This is better."

"What?"

"Nothing good would come of them staying awake."

"…!"

I had to conceal the Skeleton King's existence as much as possible. If so, it was better to remove these people from the situation from the beginning, as long as doing so didn't endanger their lives.

The fewer witnesses, the better.

Thud.

Once the last Hunter had lost consciousness, the Skeleton King nodded at my signal and snapped his fingers.

Crack-crack-crack!

Countless bones rose from somewhere and closed around the Hunters without leaving a gap. The Skeleton King looked smug.

"Done. Since this body has personally demonstrated its abilities, the safety of those humans is guaranteed."

I studied the small dome. "I don't know. I think you should reinforce it."

"Tsk, tsk. Wretched human, you are distrustful indeed. This would hold firm even against a horde of ogres."

Ogres were monsters whose terrifying strength was always considered among the highest, regardless of their Grade.

"It'd probably be fine against ogres. But those things look a little different."

"Huh?"

The Skeleton King turned to look. In the vast jungle, something was slowly rising to its feet.

Twenty meters[2583] tall. Arms and legs longer and thicker than the countless giant trees around it.

And…

One enormous eye gazing down at the earth.

A Cyclops.

Mist shrouded the mythical giant from head to toe. Its single eye turned toward us, and an eerie voice boomed like thunder.

—Intruders. Humans. Kill.

[2583] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

And the next moment—

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Along with the System notification drilling into my ears, the jungle shook.

No. It came alive.

Flap-flap!

Nameless birds shot into the sky. Beneath their beating wings, hundreds of trees rose with monstrous cries.

Ancient tree spirits from countless tales. Ents awoke from their slumber and roared.

—Gwoooooar!

—Grrrrrrrr!

One person—or rather, one monster—had watched it all in silence. He promptly changed his mind.

"…I shall reinforce the humans' barrier."

"Uh, yeah."

Crack-crack.

Far more bones than before surged upward, piling on in layer after layer.

The Skeleton King took care to finish the reinforcement, then fixed a grave stare on the advancing jungle.

"Ready, Jin?"

"Of course, King… Wait, where the hell did you learn this kind of thing?"

"The internet. It is entertaining."

"You bastard. Once we get out of here, I'm confiscating your phone."

I muttered a threat at him, then spoke under my breath.

"Inventory open. Summon."

At my command, the shaft of White Flame appeared in my empty hand. Its familiar feel was one I hadn't known in a long time.

I looked around at what had become a battlefield, and a smile touched my lips.

Let's go.

Whoosh.

[2584] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. In this martial-arts context, three jiazi describes the equivalent of 180 years of accumulated cultivation, not the cultivator's age.

Three jiazi[2584] of Scorching Yang Qi surged up from my lower dantian, became a fire dragon, and spread through every limb and bone in my body.

Chapter 557

Whew.

My breath mingled with the muggy air of the forest. Watching the enemies closing in from every direction, I quietly muttered to myself.

Keep my center low. Keep my lower body firm. When launching an attack…

Be fierce. Don't hesitate.

Flash.

The instant I half-opened my eyes, I kicked off the ground.

Bam—!

Compressed air burst from my toes, and tremendous wind pressure slammed into me. My superhuman body pushed through it. Leaning into the wind, I shot forward like a cannonball.

Whoooosh!

My hair whipped wildly. The forest blurred past.

Behind me, the Skeleton King yelled at me to take him along, but the rush of air swallowed his voice.

The hundreds of monsters advancing through the deep, sticky swamp and trampling the dense undergrowth were suddenly right in front of me.

—Gwoooooar!

Hundreds of them. Or hundreds of trees.

I didn't know which word to use for monsters called Ents, but I knew one thing.

I'll win.

That wasn't a guess. I was certain. Even the Cyclops watching from behind the Ents as though it were their king was no exception.

The three jiazi[2585] of Scorching Yang Qi coursing through me were my proof. I'd defeated countless powerful enemies to get here; I was my own witness. And the blue-white Force rising around White Flame's spearhead was the judge.

The verdict came swiftly, and it was destructive.

Now.

Hiss.

Blue flames evaporated the moisture around me. In less than an instant, White Flame's transparent spearhead had swept diagonally across the Ents at the front.

Shwaak!

There was no explosive sound. No scream.

Only a gust of wind, and a faint line drawn through the air by the Extreme Yang energy on my spearhead.

[2585] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar; three jiazi are 180 years.

The line looked like part of something that belonged in a legend.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear. First form.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Before I could even finish thinking the four syllables of the form's name, the faint line suspended in the air rippled.

The dormant blue-white flames awoke from their brief slumber.

Fwoosh.

Tiny embers flared. Feeding on the Ents' trunks, branches, and lush leaves, the flames became hellfire and devoured everything the line had touched.

Kraaaaaash—!

Blue-white light burst outward, illuminating the forest.

In its wake, the ground lay blackened and melted. Hundreds of Ents stood frozen in place. Then a clear bell rang from somewhere.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

Critical Strike!
You defeated Level 95 Corrupted Ent Great Warrior!
You defeated Level 90 Corrupted Ent Vanguard!
You defeated Level 89 Corrupted Ent Vanguard!
...
...
...
Since the level difference between you and the defeated targets is 20 or more, the EXP gained is reduced.
Since you defeated 20 or more Corrupted Ents with a single strike, bonus EXP has been awarded!
You obtained a large amount of EXP and Fame!

But the System notifications didn't end there.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have been surrounded by a great many enemies. But do not be afraid. It is not you who must retreat, but the enemy.
The effect of the Title One Against a Thousand has activated!
Number of identified enemies: 281
Since you are facing a large number of enemies, all your attributes will temporarily increase according to the number of enemies.
When fighting a large number of enemies, your Stamina consumption during battle is greatly reduced, and you will not easily feel fatigue!

One Against a Thousand.

Two months ago, I'd earned the Title by single-handedly sweeping away the undead army serving the Arch Lich. At last, it was showing its worth.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The bells rang in quick succession, and all my attributes—including **Strength** and **Stamina**—rose slightly.

But that wasn't all. One of the greatest effects of **One Against a Thousand** was its ability to maximize a single attribute.

SYSTEM

Intimidation has increased dramatically!
Your majesty and aura, rising like a wildfire, are overwhelming your enemies!
Your enemies are greatly intimidated by your Intimidation!
Your allies' morale is greatly increased by your Intimidation!

Intimidation.

The power to suppress enemies and encourage allies. An ability that could change the flow of an entire battlefield instead of affecting only me. The System's information hadn't been wrong in the slightest.

The encirclement closing around me faltered. Thick branches that had been thrashing violently stopped in place.

—Gwooooo…

The Ents—evil spirits dwelling in giant trees—let out frightened cries. Hundreds of pairs of black eyes trembled between their hard bark.

Fear.

I knew the feeling. Once, it had been mine. Now it belonged to the enemies facing me.

Exhilaration rose in my chest as I took a step forward.

Step.

—Gwoooooar…

—Grrk. Gwooooo…

Rumble-rumble-rumble.

The Ents retreated as I advanced.

No—the entire jungle moved.

The magical power they released as they huddled together was crushed beneath the wave of qi and Intimidation radiating from me.

Power. Momentum.

They couldn't match me in either of the two things that decided a battle. I had no reason not to fight, and no reason I couldn't win.

There was, of course, one variable.

—Kraaaaaaaar!

The Cyclops.

The mythical giant's roar shook the jungle. Its single eye was larger than a boulder, and the Ents that had been edging backward on their roots flinched.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Giant's Roar has activated!
The effect of Intimidation has been slightly neutralized!
Some enemies have escaped the pressure of Intimidation!

A fitting ability for the boss monster of this Gate.

But even the Cyclops couldn't completely lift the pressure on them, and I had no intention of giving it more time.

No. Correction.

We had no intention of giving it more time.

"Haaap!"

Krkrkrkrk! Pow-pow-pow!

With a powerful shout, a spear of bone shot through the air and pierced the Ents.

The Skeleton King had caught up with me. He was raising hell.

“Come at me, you worthless monsters!”

“…”

The bastard had completely lost track of what he was.

Apparently getting the full benefit of **One Against a Thousand**, he charged ahead without a thought.

“How dare you oppose this exalted body! Die! Die! Dieee!”

Papapapat!

The Skeleton King might have been a little off his rocker, but he was still a Named Monster who had undergone an evolution. There was no denying his power.

Bones erupted from the ground and the air, snapping branches and piercing Ent trunks without pause.

Pow-pow-pow!

“How dare you wave those adorable little leaves before this body!”

Craack!

“No matter how many of you attack, it’s like striking bone with an egg!”

—Gwoooooar!

The Ents’ mournful cries rang through the scene of forest destruction.

The Skeleton King’s arrival had cleared a path. I shot down it like an arrow.

Whoooosh! Slash!

I swept past like the wind, slashing in every direction. Flames crossed the air, and the Ents vanished before they could even scream.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Hearing the bells ring noisily in my ears, I twisted aside. A tree trunk shot toward me with tremendous force, grazed my side, and pierced the ground.

Boom!

Mud exploded upward. I stepped onto another stem whipping toward me and sprang lightly into the air.

Tap. Swish.

Since Mungyeong’s lessons, my movements had grown smoother and more precise. I glided forward like a feather and arrived before an unusually massive tree.

Level 102 Corrupted Ent Elder

—H-u-man! D-i-e!

Its level wasn’t the only thing that was high. The Ent Elder had enough intelligence to speak.

I brought my spearhead down diagonally without hesitation.

“Welcome, Chikorita.[2586]”

[2586] Chikorita is a Grass-type Pokémon.

—…!

Whoosh. Slash!

The hundreds of branches it hastily gathered to defend itself were useless. So were the thorns it fired at me.

Along the path of my spearhead, the tree—several meters[2587] around—slowly split apart.

Crash! Fwoosh!

It fell with a thunderous crash and burst into flames.

I kicked off its stump, dense growth rings exposed, and shot upward. At last, I came face-to-face with the gigantic being blocking out the sky.

Level 130 'Red Eye' Cyclops

There it was. The master of this jungle. A savage, one-eyed giant with hundreds of Ents for servants.

Now that I could identify it, I saw that its level was higher than any monster that had served the Arch Lich during the Small Cataclysm. It even had an epithet. A Named Monster.

A Named Monster in a low-grade Gate like this…

The thought weighed on me, but I had to put it aside. A gigantic shadow was plunging down from high above.

Whoom!

A rock over ten meters[2588] in diameter—no, something closer to a meteorite—crushed the air beneath it as it fell.

I chose to break through it head-on.

Finish it quickly.

I shot upward. The rock plunged down.

At the moment of impact, I poured the Scorching Yang Qi within White Flame into the tip of its spearhead and thrust at the rock's center.

And then…

Slash.

Like a hot knife cutting through cheese, the spearhead slid into the rock and turned.

Krkrkrk.

It broke through at a single point. Mighty Force tore through the interior, and cracks spread across the enormous rock's surface.

Kraaaaaaang!

It shattered with a thunderous roar, scattering hundreds—thousands—of fragments in every direction.

[2587] Several meters of circumference is roughly 10–20 ft.

[2588] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

—…!

The Cyclops's single red eye widened. Unable to withstand the force, it staggered.

Rumble. Crack!

—Gwoooooar!

The ground broke beneath the giant's movements. Small-bodied Ents were trampled underfoot and screamed.

Neither the Cyclops nor I paid them any attention.

All that mattered was bringing down the enemy in front of us.

—Huuuuuu… maaaaan…

The Cyclops's roar sounded as though it had been slowed to 0.1 speed.

In that slowed world, I stepped onto empty air and shot upward again without a moment's hesitation.

Bam!

Stepping on Empty Air.

Compressed air exploded beneath my toes, propelling me farther and higher.

Whoooom.

Sensing danger, the Cyclops swung its fist too late. It was slow enough to make me yawn.

Boom!

The punch split the air with a terrifying sound. But by the time its fist struck empty space, I had already passed it and risen above its head.

Gooooong.

Blue flames spread across the spearhead, heavy with Scorching Yang Qi.

A force both sharp and destructive.

The second and final form of the Blazing Flame Divine Spear, which concentrated three hundred years of the Fire Gate Clan's macho spirit—the time-honored clan with absolutely no concept of retreat.

Heavenly Strike.

Blue flames fell toward the giant's head.

Shwooooooosh. Slash!

Chapter 558

Flash.

The man's eyes flew open.

For a moment, he stared dazedly into space. Then he began piecing together what had happened.

An F-rank Gate. Goblins. An earthquake. And…

Jin Taekyung.

That last name brought everything back. The man sprang up as if launched by a spring.

"Gaaaaah!"

There was just one problem. He had the large build of a tank, and there wasn't much room to spring up in.

Thump. Bang!

"Gah! Huh?"

He struck his head on the ceiling. His cry of pain cut off as his eyes widened.

It hurt. It really hurt. But if he could feel pain, that meant…

I-I'm alive!

He'd never expected to find himself thinking like a webnovel protagonist.

As the tension finally left his body, he realized he was lying inside a vehicle. An ambulance, to be precise.

An ambulance?

He was lucky to have escaped death, but this wasn't necessarily a good sign. Surviving only to be left disabled would be its own kind of misfortune.

He hurriedly began checking himself from head to toe.

That was when—

Bang. Rattle.

The door flew open, and light poured in. He raised both arms to shield his face.

Or perhaps it was the dazzling beauty of the woman who had opened it that made him do that.

"Oh, you're awake. I thought I heard something as I was passing by."

He stammered at the beautiful woman who had appeared out of nowhere. "W-Who are you?"

"You're Team Leader Lee Seungyeop, right? Thirty-three years old, a freelancer with no Guild affiliation."

"H-How do you know who I am?"

"Questions in a moment. First, are you feeling all right?"

Her gentle but firm interruption caught him off guard, and he nodded.

"You should be fine. All you had were a few scrapes—hardly enough to call injuries. The others, too…"

The others?

That casual mention made his eyes fly open.

"R-Right! My team! Are they all right? Did anyone die or get hurt?"

"Your team members are all safe. But if you keep shouting, my ears won't be."

"Really? You're sure? Guh, is that really true?"

"I know someone who always stakes something dirty on it at times like this. I don't have any balls, so I'll stake my ovaries. Satisfied?"

She delivered the answer without missing a beat, then continued.

"And to answer your earlier question, I checked your belongings. Thanks to that, we were able to complete your identity verification quickly."

Tap.

She set down a small extradimensional Pocket and a briefing board. A short message had been scrawled across the board's white surface in atrocious handwriting.

Go, Hunter Lee Seungyeop!

—Jin Taekyung

The woman gave a quiet laugh.

"That had actually fallen on the ground. Someone picked it up and handed it to me himself. Said it was going to be a family heirloom, so we couldn't let you lose it."

Team Leader Lee Seungyeop's eyes widened.

"Then the person who handed it to you was…?"

"If a name just came to mind, you've got it."

Her neat eyebrows lifted. Her voice was as open and bright as her features.

"Oh, I haven't introduced myself. I'm Song Song."

"Song? What kind of song?"

"…It'll be faster if I just give you my business card. Here."

Swish.

The Team Leader took the card from her long, pale fingers and stared.

"Peace Guild?"

"Officially, I'm the Healer Team Leader. I'm temporarily heading the emergency rescue team, too."

"…Oh."

He caught his breath. Even someone as busy making ends meet as he was knew about the Peace Guild.

You'd have to be a monster not to.

Jin Taekyung himself belonged to it.

Its enormous financial resources and ability to draw public attention had fueled explosive growth in just a few months. The Peace Guild was no longer some unremarkable small or medium-sized Guild.

I hear it's harder to get into the Peace Guild than Ares Guild these days.

It offered Hunters some of the best treatment in the industry, and its prospects seemed limitless. Of course talented people were flocking to it. After Lee Jungryong's national funeral a week ago, he'd even heard that Hunters from Ares Guild had transferred there instead of renewing their contracts.

And the woman in front of him was a team leader at that very Guild. She looked barely into her twenties, but she was already a big deal.

Come to think of it, he might have seen her celebrity-like face on television once or twice.

"But… what exactly is the emergency rescue team? I haven't heard of it before."

"Exactly what it sounds like. It's a new team dedicated solely to rescuing people."

"I know Guilds of a certain size have rescue teams. But neither my team nor I belong to the Peace Guild."

Freelance Hunters and small Guilds relied on government agencies for help; even mid-sized Guilds commonly ran their own rescue teams. He couldn't understand why the Peace Guild had shown up for them.

"Would you rather we hadn't?"

"N-No! How could I think that? I'm grateful, of course. We nearly died in that Mutated Gate, and you saved us."

Song Song gave a quiet laugh.

"Then that settles it. It's what we came to do."

"What?"

"The Peace Guild emergency rescue team is on a trial run, focusing on mid- and low-grade Gates in the capital region. We're working with government agencies, and we respond to all Hunters. You could call it volunteer work for public safety."

"Volunteer… work?"

"Oh, I and the others get paid, of course."

He stared past Song Song's shoulder. Hunters were hurrying in every direction, each with the Peace Guild emblem on their chest.

Volunteer work? With this many people?

No matter how much of a golden goose a modern Hunter Guild was, most of its income still came from Gates. Guilds paid Hunters enormous salaries because they could make even greater profits from raids.

But the Peace Guild had sent these Hunters out to rescue people instead—and paid them properly to do it.

They all look like at least mid-grade Hunters.

Dozens of them wore equipment that looked expensive even at a glance. As a low-grade Hunter, he couldn't begin to guess how much the Peace Guild had spent on them today.

"Um. You said you're Team Leader Song Song?"

"Yes. Go ahead."

"I was wondering… are there treatment fees? Rescue fees? Anything like that?"

"No. Have you ever seen a firefighter rescue someone and send them a bill?"

"Then…?"

"Transport and treatment are free, obviously. Oh, and if anyone's been hurt psychologically, we cover counseling too. For trauma and that sort of thing."

"…?"

Wait. What treatment? Did I hear that right?

He stared at her, dazed, then asked in all sincerity, "Does the Peace Guild dig its money out of the ground?"

Song Song winked.

"No, but the man funding us has quite a lot of it."

"The man funding you?"

"You know him. You even got his autograph."

"…!"

"Anyway, there's someone like that. He complains every day that he feels like he's being bled dry, but he's smiling the whole time."

A smile touched Song Song's lips as she thought of him.

When she'd first met him, she'd wondered what kind of lunatic he was. Watching him since then had taught her what it meant to be a true Hunter. What it meant to care about people.

"You. Let's do a job together."

"…That sounds like a line I've heard somewhere. First, you should know I'm not overseas Chinese.[2589]"

Jin Taekyung had come to her out of nowhere with that proposal a week ago. For a moment, she'd thought he wanted her to join Gold Moon[2590]—no, Ares Guild—and act as a spy.

What he'd said next had been nothing like she expected.

"You're better than I expected, Taurus."

To be a little more honest, he'd been kind of cool this time.

[2589] *Overseas Chinese* (*hwagyo*) means ethnic Chinese living outside China, including a long-settled community in Korea. The exchange echoes the Korean crime film *New World* (2013), whose ethnically Chinese hero is recruited by a superior for an undercover job.

[2590] Gold Moon is the crime syndicate that the undercover hero infiltrates in the film *New World*, the same film the earlier exchange echoes.

The same had been true when he'd used the money from selling the Black Wyvern's carcass to establish a charitable foundation. Every now and then, he showed her an unexpected side of himself.

Song Song let out a quiet laugh and looked up at the sky.

It was January, and the cold hadn't yet faded. But the sunlight overhead was warm.

Kiiiiing.

—Jin Taekyung. Iris recognition complete.

A red light swept across my pupil, accompanied by a mechanical voice. I stepped through the door as it opened automatically and entered the Guild House.

Everyone going about their work stopped in their tracks, as though they'd arranged it in advance.

"W-Welcome."

"Welcome!"

"Thank you for your hard work!"

"Ah, yes. Hello, everyone."

I told them not to do this. What is this, a gangster office?

I gave them an awkward smile. I still couldn't get used to it.

The Skeleton King whispered beside me, "Wretched human. This does not seem right."

"You, of all people? You have thoughts like that—"

Before I could finish, he strode forward and pointed at a Hunter who looked like a new recruit.

"You there. You're bending only eighty degrees at the waist. Make it ninety. Or you could try a grandjeol.[2591]"

"Y-Yes! Understood!"

"…"

Don't go adjusting their angles. And what exactly does he understand?

Just watching was enough to leave me speechless. I stopped the Guild member from attempting a grandjeol[2592], kindly advised him not to listen to this idiot, and finally made it to my destination.

Familiar faces were waiting there.

"Taekyung!"

"Welcome."

[2591] A comically exaggerated Korean bow performed with the body inverted.

[2592] A comically exaggerated Korean bow performed with the body inverted.

Im Kkeokjeong spread both arms to greet me. Beside him, Team Leader Choi was busy dealing with something.

“Take it easy. Take it easy. What if you reopen your wounds?”

“I’m just happy to see you, punk.”

“We see each other every day.”

As soon as I sat Im Kkeokjeong down—he was still undergoing rehabilitation training—Team Leader Choi suddenly spoke.

“I received a report over the hotline. A Named Monster appeared?”

“A Cyclops. Plus three hundred Ents for good measure.”

“A Cyclops in an F-rank Gate… It was fortunate you happened to be nearby, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“They all knelt before this body’s majesty.”

“One more word and you’ll be listening on your knees.”

“…Sorry.”

That shut him up. Team Leader Choi handed me a folder.

“What’s this?”

“The data you requested. I compiled the number of Mutated Gates that have appeared recently in Korea and elsewhere in Asia.”

It didn’t take long to go through. Once I’d found what I was looking for, I let out a groan.

“Five in Korea alone over the past month…”

“The frequency of Mutated Gates is rising explosively. The incident in Sichuan Province is the most notable example.”

Mutated Gates were extremely rare. Even in Korea, with its hundreds of Gates, they normally appeared only once or twice a year—three times at most. Yet last month’s count had already passed five.

And it’s already happened twice this month, counting the one I just dealt with.

It was a bizarre phenomenon I couldn’t explain. But the fact that events in Murim came to mind right now couldn’t be a coincidence.

Something’s happening.

Tap. Tap-tap.

I drummed my fingers on the table in silence, then asked, “What about North America and Europe?”

“I expect the situation is similar. But for something more certain, I’ve requested data from someone I trust.”

“Someone you trust?”

The moment I asked, every one of my senses snapped awake.

Whoooooosh.

A sudden storm of qi.

An immense amount of mana, far beyond what even an A-rank Hunter possessed, was converging somewhere in the Guild House.

This is…

I knew that flow of mana. And I recognized the distinctive presence within it.

“Team Leader Choi, don’t tell me…”

“It’s the person you’re thinking of. Though I didn’t expect him to come in person.”

At Team Leader Choi’s calm answer, the Skeleton King turned to me with a bewildered expression.

“Wretched human. Whom are you talking about?”

“Your dad.”

“…?”

His confusion lasted only a moment. Someone’s message magic entered all our minds, and a smile spread across his face.

—Have you all been well?

The voice had a hip-hop soul and groove to it. I gave a quiet laugh as a name came to mind.

Magic Johnson.

The American Grand Mage had come to visit the Peace Guild.

Chapter 559

Teleportation.

The spatial-transference magic commonly called Teleport was notoriously difficult, even among mages. Get the coordinates wrong and you could die in an instant. It consumed so much mana that a mage attempting long-distance travel might well clutch the back of their neck and collapse.

The ultimate shitty cost-to-benefit ratio.

But in the end, what mattered was *who* used it.

In the hands of a Supreme Peak master, even the Three Calamities Sword Technique could rival a divine technique. The same principle applied to a Grand Mage—one of only three among the world's seven billion people.

"Fucking Korea. I think this every time, but it's too damn far away. I almost got motion sickness on the way here."

I gave a quiet laugh at Magic Johnson, the dark-skinned Grand Mage grumbling in front of me.

"Motion sickness is a small price to pay for crossing continents. Any other mage would be seasick on the Sanzu River[2593] by now."

"Sanzu River? What's that? Is it like Cheonggyecheon in Seoul?[2594]"

"…A little different. Anyway, let's move on."

Magic Johnson, who had turned Seoul into a city of hell in one sentence, spotted the people inside the room and broke into a wide smile.

"Hey, what's up, gays! It's been a while."

Team Leader Choi answered Time magazine's pick for the "world's most influential LGBTQ person" in the firmest voice imaginable.

"It's *guys*, Mr. Johnson. Not *gays*."

"Choi, now you're hurting my feelings. I came running the moment you asked."

"I appreciate you coming in person, but couldn't you have sent it by secure email?"

"Is that any way to treat someone you haven't seen in a while?"

"If I remember correctly, it hasn't even been a week since we last met. Isn't that right, Mr. Jin Taekyung?"

I nodded.

"That's true. Johnson was here for the national funeral, too."

The national funeral held this time had been enormous. Nearly a million citizens had come to pay their respects, and influential figures from countries around the world had traveled to Korea.

[2593] The Sanzu River is a Buddhist river associated with the boundary between life and death.

[2594] Cheonggyecheon is a restored stream running through downtown Seoul, popular as a walkway.

That said plenty about the influence Lee Jungryong had wielded in life. Quite a few of the mourners were presidents, prompting one news outlet to call the gathering a “summit meeting.”

Magic Johnson, one of the symbols of the United States, had been among them.

“Hey, Jin. Is this how you’re going to act? I didn’t come to meet you people. I came simply to pay my respects.”

“Your respects?”

“That’s right. I came to see off an old comrade.”

“Then why did you go to a gay bar in Itaewon? You even changed your face with illusion magic.”

“…Who told you that ridiculous nonsense?”

“The guy who went with you. Pretty conclusive testimony.”

There was no trace left of his initial delight at seeing Johnson. The victim of that day, the Skeleton King, spoke with an enraged expression.

“I knew something was wrong when something touched this body’s backside. That damned human tricked me.”

“You ungrateful monster-murder fucker…”

Look at that expression. I’d believe it if Time had named him the “world’s most violent LGBTQ person.”

Magic Johnson muttered in a threatening voice, then noticed everyone’s eyes on him and quickly adopted a serious expression.

“Don’t misunderstand. I only went to experience Korean culture.”

“Did you sell your tribute to an old comrade on eBay?”

“Jin, don’t be like that. I paid my respects at the funeral ceremony. You know better than anyone what Mr. Lee was like.”

I did. Who could know better than me?

And Johnson was one of the very few people who knew what had happened at the Arch Lich’s stronghold.

“Anyway, we’re meeting again, so let’s stop talking about this. You there, you agree, don’t you? Your name was… Robin Hood, right?”

Unfortunately, Korea’s Robin Hood—Im Kkeokjeong—didn’t have a translation Item. He answered with a frozen expression.

“I-I’m fine, thank you. And you…”

“I’m fine, of course. But I’m afraid what I have to tell you isn’t good news.”

Swish.

With a sigh, Johnson held out a memory chip no bigger than a fingernail.

Team Leader Choi took it and examined it, his eyes sharpening.

“Is this the information I asked for?”

“That’s right. I had to pull a few strings for the first time in a while.”

"I'll thank you after I've reviewed it."

"Take your time."

Tap. Whooooooosh.

It happened in an instant.

Team Leader Choi tapped somewhere beneath the table. Every window and opening in his private office was covered, and unseen mana spread across them like a curtain.

Magic?

If I'd noticed it, there was no way Johnson hadn't. He looked around the office with interest.

"Seven overlapping spells. Your security is tighter than I expected. Only a handful of mages in our Guild could manage magic at this level… Whose work is it?"

"Someone who has been my hands and feet since I was young."

Kim the Butler and Johnson had never met face-to-face. After that brief answer, Team Leader Choi inserted the chip into his smartphone, and a holographic video sprang up above the screen.

—Krrrraaaaaash!

With a thunderous roar, the ground within a radius of several dozen meters[2595] heaved over, spraying sand in every direction. It looked like an earthquake.

Around a hundred Hunters of different ethnicities shouted and cursed.

—"Fuck!"

—"Spread out! Spread out now! They're coming!"

—"Healer! Healeeer!"

Screams and shouts filled the scene. Several buildings were collapsing among the dead trees and sand dunes.

Im Kkeokjeong's eyes widened as he realized what that meant.

"M-Monster Wave?"

Correct. Modern buildings had no business being inside a Gate.

Every Gate contained at least a minimal amount of mana, and its Grade was determined by the total amount of mana it held.

But if a monster appeared whose power far exceeded the Gate's Grade, that was a different matter.

That was a Mutated Gate.

A Mutated Gate was already a serious problem. But if the presence of the higher-grade monster caused the Gate's mana to exceed the total amount it could contain, an even greater disaster awaited.

A Monster Wave.

[2595] Several dozen meters is roughly 100–300 ft.

When a sturdy dam gave way under pressure, the water it had held back came flooding out.

That was what we were seeing in the hologram.

—Sssshhhk!

More than ten enormous scorpions let out strange cries. Buried deep in the sand, they sent their tails shooting up through the surface. Screams erupted, and blood sprayed in every direction.

—“Gaaaaah!”

—“Joseph! Save Joseph!”

—“Commence volley fire!”

Krrrraack!

At the very moment humans and monsters threw themselves at one another in an attempt to kill each other—

Ffft.

The holographic video filling the office vanished as though it had been washed away.

Team Leader Choi had stopped the video. He spoke in a subdued voice.

“When did this happen?”

Johnson’s expression darkened.

“Four days ago. The Mojave Desert. It stretches across several states, but this was closer to Arizona. I don’t know the exact coordinates.”

I frowned as I listened.

“Four days ago?”

“Yes. Four days ago.”

“There should’ve been an official announcement by now.”

Gates were like ticking time bombs with a slim chance of going off. That was why every country kept watch on them, stationed government Hunters—the so-called “bomb disposal squads”—around the country, and required incidents to be announced within a set period.

Then why has everything been so quiet?

Mutated Gates were rare. Monster Waves were dozens of times rarer. An incident like this should have made headlines.

Team Leader Choi and I had both been watching news from around the world lately. It made no sense that neither of us had heard about it.

That left only one answer.

“There was no official announcement.”

Johnson gave a small nod.

“That’s right. The Ministry of National Defense stepped in and covered the whole thing up. As neatly as those monsters turned over the desert.”

"They can do that?"

"Can they? Come on, Jin. This was handled in secret by the United States Ministry of National Defense. You should be asking what they *can't* do."

He let out a dry laugh.

"Twenty-two people died and thirty-five were injured, but that doesn't change anything. It happened at a military base closed to civilians. Probably made it easier to hide."

"But that's… a cover-up."

"It is. It violates the constitution, too—the one extensively revised after the Great Cataclysm. But sometimes a kind lie is better than a cold truth."

"…!"

For a moment, it felt as though someone had struck me in the back of the head.

I knew this was wrong. And yet I'd been thinking the same thing as Johnson.

Dark Heaven.

People unprepared for the truth were bound to be thrown into confusion when it arrived without warning. That was true of Dark Heaven in Murim. I, too, believed it was too soon for their identities to become known.

But that wasn't the only reason the back of my head felt numb.

The vague fear I'd been carrying had just become real.

"How many times?"

I hadn't said what I was asking about. Johnson's face went rigid. He understood.

"Johnson."

"…Fuck."

He muttered the curse like a sigh, then turned to Team Leader Choi.

"Choi, how many videos are stored on the chip I gave you?"

Team Leader Choi stared silently at the smartphone screen before answering in a voice that sounded almost like a groan.

"Thirty-two."

"Right. Two were Monster Waves. The rest were Mutated Gates. And that's only what I managed to get my hands on."

No one could doubt Magic Johnson's standing and influence in the United States. But even he could not compare with the intelligence-gathering capabilities of the Ministry of National Defense of the United States, which still claimed to be the most powerful nation in the world.

Thirty-two incidents in the data Johnson managed to acquire alone.

How many more had there been?

At that moment, Team Leader Choi and I fell silent at the same time, as though we had arranged it in advance.

"Wait. Hold on."

The Skeleton King had been diligently counting something on his fingers. Now he looked at Magic Johnson with eyes as round as lanterns.

“Human I’m no longer grateful to—doesn’t what you just said mean incidents like this have been happening every single day?”

“You loose-lipped monster. Aren’t you taking this a little too lightly?”

“Huh?”

I would have been happier not hearing what Johnson said next.

“Not over the past month. They all happened in the past week.”

“…!”

“…!”

A suffocating silence settled over the room. Then the voice of the only person who hadn’t understood Johnson rang out.

“I-I’m fine, thank you. And you?”

“…”

“…”

To hell with ‘and you.‘ Holy shit. Fuck.

Chapter 560

Holy shit. What the fuck.

Even if I used every English-language curse I knew, I still couldn't express how fucked things were.

Thirty-two times in a single week.

An outrageous number. And that was only what Magic Johnson had managed to find out.

I didn't know the exact count, but it was bound to be higher than thirty-two.

Yeah. Maybe this was inevitable.

The United States was ninety-eight times the size of Korea and had nearly twenty times as many Gates.

It had been Demon King Asmodeus's top-priority target during the Great Cataclysm and suffered tremendous damage throughout the war.

Ironically, what had restored the United States to its position as the world's greatest power was what the war had left behind: Gates.

Oil fields.

Modern Gates were, quite literally, a new and far more abundant kind of oil field.

More than thirty years had passed since the disaster that swallowed the world. Monster byproducts had long fetched high prices, and Magic Gems had become an environmentally friendly energy source.

The survivors had built a civilization even grander and more dazzling atop the ruins of the war.

But…

"The party seems to be over."

As Magic Johnson had put it, the winners' lavish party was over.

The oil fields called Gates had caught fire. Explosions would soon erupt all over the world. No—they were already happening.

For now, an invisible hand was hiding them all.

"Ah, fuck…"

The words came out like a groan. I turned to Team Leader Choi.

"Things aren't like this in Korea too, are they?"

What I meant was: had other incidents happened without my knowing, like the ones in the United States?

Team Leader Choi thought for a moment before answering.

"I always keep unexpected possibilities in mind, but as far as I know, there aren't any."

"Team Leader Choi, we need to be sure."

"I know. That's why I'm thinking of arranging another meeting while I have the chance."

Magic Johnson, who had been listening, asked, "A meeting? With whom?"

"Some people I've come to know through circumstance. I doubt they lied to me, but you never know what people are thinking."

"True. Especially politicians."

Team Leader Choi nodded quietly at Johnson's offhand remark.

"So you knew."

"Choi looked awfully busy at Mr. Lee's national funeral. A lot of people were looking for you."

Team Leader Choi and I had attended Lee Jungryong's national funeral and paid our respects. Our private feelings were another matter, but maintaining our public image wasn't the only reason we had gone.

"They're looking for a new shadow to shelter under," Team Leader Choi said. "That's what I wanted, too."

Figures from politics and business, along with key members of mid-sized and large Guilds that Ares Guild had kept under its thumb, had shown enormous interest in us.

More than half of them had approached me first, of course. But I'd known from the start what I would say.

Don't talk to a nobody Hunter like me. Talk to our Team Leader Choi.

Earning a place at Lee Jungryong's national funeral, where every kind of heavyweight had gathered, meant they were people who had claimed their own victories in society after fighting tooth and nail.

They understood exactly what I meant and immediately set about arranging meetings with Team Leader Choi.

"The powerless are ignored," Johnson said. "But people reach out to the powerful from every direction. The world may have changed, but that hasn't."

It was the sharp truth.

No one had sought out Team Leader Choi or me before. Now the Peace Guild had risen to become the only force capable of standing against Ares Guild.

The public might not know it, but the people at the top of society knew it better than anyone.

By now, political and business figures were probably calculating what they stood to gain from a fight between the two Guilds—and whose shadow would be cooler to stand in.

The owners of the mid-sized and large Guilds probably wanted to use this opportunity to escape Ares Guild's excessive monopoly as well.

Team Leader Choi had gained new allies and the power they held.

It was his first step toward digesting the entire feast that was Ares.

Perhaps that was why, when he spoke again, the voice that emerged from between his immaculate lips carried more strength than ever.

“I won’t turn away the hands they’ve offered.”

Magic Johnson studied him for a moment, then spoke up.

“So… it seems the rumor was true.”

“What rumor?”

“That rumor. The one saying that Choi is connected to *him*.”

“There’s no reason to hide it anymore. It’s true.”

Johnson’s eyes widened.

“I didn’t expect Choi to admit it so easily. Have you told everyone else you’ve met recently?”

“No. But even without saying it, they know, and I know. We know whose blood runs through my veins.”

A quiet laugh escaped the Grand Mage’s thick lips.

“Right. No one can deny that fact. He’s the only pureblood in existence in the twenty-first century.”

No living noble or royal could compare to Team Leader Choi. Not even if the haughty Prince Felix of the United Kingdom became king.

If his ancestor had built a vast empire upon which the sun never set, then Cheon Taemin was the savior who had allowed billions of people to see the sun rise on another day.

“And it was wise not to mention him directly,” Johnson said. “People trust a man who keeps his own counsel and doesn’t reveal himself too easily.”

“Thank you for the compliment.”

“No need. It’s the truth.”

There was no trace of Johnson’s usual playful manner. He went on in a calm voice.

“But Choi, keep this in mind. Your grandfather, wherever he may be now, and I have always known what came first. We risked our lives and fought for a better future. Is that what people in the East call a greater cause?”

“…!”

He was telling Team Leader Choi, without saying it outright, that the crisis on our doorstep had to come before Ares Guild.

After a brief silence, Team Leader Choi answered, “I’ll remember, Mr. Johnson. But I’m not going after Ares Guild for personal reasons alone.”

“I know what kind of man Choi is. You want to weaken Ares in case the worst happens and build up the Peace Guild’s own strength. Teeth like yours aren’t enough to swallow a tiger.”

Team Leader Choi smiled bitterly.

“A hyena… I can’t deny it.”

Lee Jungryong might be gone, but Ares was still Ares.

The Peace Guild had grown rapidly, its name seared into minds around the world because of me. But we couldn’t bring down the impregnable fortress Ares Guild had spent decades building in a single blow.

“Keep building your strength, so long as you’re not doing it for personal glory,” Johnson said. “The Wizard Guild and I will help. If you need it, I can introduce you to a few friends of mine, too.”

“Yes. That’s what I intend to do. The bad blood from the past hasn’t run its course.”

“You mean that young fellow. Mr. Seok.”

Magic Johnson suddenly drew his brows together.

“I haven’t spent much time with him, but I know he isn’t particularly kind. Isn’t that right, Jin?”

I nodded at once.

“He’s a fucking asshole.”

“I had a feeling from his surname. Even the way it’s pronounced sounds like ‘suck.‘ And I didn’t like it when he attacked Jin at the Arch Lich’s stronghold while we were still investigating…”

Johnson’s expression grew serious.

“He gives off an even more dangerous smell now than he did before. Jin, you were right in front of me. Didn’t you notice?”

“…”

“Jin?”

I hesitated before answering. “Well, I did fart in front of you.”

“What the fuck…”

“Even so, there’s no need to swear. And Go Jun was already a dangerous bastard to begin with.”

“Whew. True. But please try not to fart when I’m standing behind you from now on.”

“…Yes.”

I had been uneasy about having Magic Johnson at my back too, but I had been the one to fart in the end, so I had nothing to say.

I looked away as I answered. Johnson’s nose twitched.

“All right. That’s enough for today. Whatever anyone else thinks, I want you two to know I trust you completely.”

He looked warmly at Team Leader Choi and me, then turned to the two standing there blankly—no, the one man and one monster.

“You two as well, of course.”

The Skeleton King and Im Kkeokjeong answered at the same time.

"Just don't take us to a gay bar."

"I-I don't speak English."

"…Very reassuring."

Johnson's face said otherwise. He pulled a small glass bottle from inside his clothes and drained it.

I recognized it as a potion to replenish spent mana.

"Are you leaving?"

"I should get back. I'm going to be busy from now on, too. There are friends I haven't seen in a while whom I need to contact."

"Friends?"

"The ones I mentioned earlier. About half have retired, but they can still be a great help. Oh, if Choi wants, I could take you to them right now. What do you say?"

Team Leader Choi hesitated under Magic Johnson's eager gaze, then quickly shook his head.

"N-No, that's all right."

"What a shame. My friend Joseph was interested in Choi."

"I'm disappointed too, but maybe next time… Wait. Did you say Joseph?"

"Unless your hearing's gone, you heard right."

"Then… do you mean former United States President Joseph Biden?"

"That's right. He retired quite a while ago, but we meet for a drink about once a month. He's so old he can hardly drink anymore, though."

"…!"

Team Leader Choi wasn't the only one shocked. My mouth fell open, and so did Im Kkeokjeong's.

"*That* Joseph Biden?"

"Ah, I know! I know Joseph Biden!"

I didn't care whether the name of the American president was Chakumba Okumbo or Kim Cheol Soo, but I had heard the name Joseph Biden many times since my days at the Hunter training camp.

The Great Cataclysm had struck during his presidency. He'd had it worse than the mayor of New York in a superhero movie.

Would you look at those connections.

In the United States, he was practically a second Founding Father after George Washington.

I knew Magic Johnson was a big deal, but I hadn't realized his connections were this impressive.

"Don't look at me like that. Joseph and I have been ball buddies for nearly fifty years. Most people don't know we're close."

"…!"

Team Leader Choi froze. Johnson hurriedly added, “Forget the ‘ball’ part. We’re just friends. Best friends.”

“Whew.”

“Shit. Do I really have to explain myself?”

“Mr. Johnson, we have a saying in Korea: you reap what you sow.”

“Damn it. I really got what I deserved. So, what are you going to do, Choi?”

Team Leader Choi answered without hesitation.

“Let’s go. I’ll take you up on your offer.”

“Good idea. You might get a little motion sick traveling between continents, though.”

“What’s a little motion sickness compared to this?”

Team Leader Choi answered calmly and took the hand Magic Johnson held out to him.

With a light nod, an enormous amount of mana wrapped tightly around their entire bodies.

Whoooosh!

At that exact moment, a blinding flash erupted and sent their figures flying somewhere else.

Brrrrrrr.

All three smartphones left behind—Im Kkeokjeong’s, the Skeleton King’s, and mine—began vibrating violently.

Chapter 561

Brrrrrrr.

A smartphone suddenly began vibrating. I, Im Kkeokjeong, and finally the Skeleton King checked the screen in rapid succession before opening our mouths one after another.

“What’s this?”

“T-Taekyung!”

“Oh. Ohoho. Look at this, you primitive humans. A girl-group member has sent this body a DM.”

“…”

“…”

That fucking bastard. I told him to stop screwing around on social media.

No wonder his phone was ringing when he isn’t even in the group chat.

I felt like stomping him until his illusion magic shattered, but that wasn’t important right now.

Which girl-group member… No. Another incident like this?

I barely swallowed my thoughts and stared at the smartphone screen.

Song Song had posted an urgent message in the group chat for the Peace Guild’s founding members, including Team Leader Choi and me.

> **Peace Guild**
>
> └ **Song Song:** Hey hey heyyy
>
> └ **Song Song:** C-rank Gate anomaly.
>
> └ **Song Song:** Just heard from the government hotline.
>
> └ **Song Song:** They say the magical power readings are skyrocketing.
>
> └ **Song Song:** Fuck; why aren’t you reading this?
>
> └ **Song Song:** If you’ve read it, answer me, you crazy bastard.
>
> └ **Butler Kim:** Sorry. I’m at the Blue House[2596] right now.
>
> └ **Song Song:** S-sorry;; I didn’t know it was you, Butler Kim;;; Please get back to what you were doing…
>
> └ **Butler Kim:** Of course. Have a happy day too, Song-i.
>
> └ **Song Song:** Huh. Everyone but one person has read it?
>
> └ **Song Song:** Whoever’s seen this, get over there and check it out as fast as you can.

[2596] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea’s president.

> ㄴ **Song Song:** It's far from me, and I have something to take care of, so I can't go right away.
> ㄴ **Song Song:** [Map attached]
> ㄴ **Song Song:** ?
> ㄴ **Song Song:** Oh, but now that I've checked, that Gate is kind of…
> ㄴ **Song Song:** Just go for now.
> ㄴ **Song Song:** Especially you, Jin Taekyung. Reply as soon as you read this.

Where is it?

What kind of Gate would make her react like that?

I put my questions aside, left a reply saying I had seen the message, and checked the attached map. The moment I did, I understood why Song Song had reacted that way.

"Ah. Hmm."

The location was definitely a little… awkward.

Im Kkeokjeong checked the map a beat later, and his face hardened.

"Taekyung. Is this…?"

"Probably exactly where you think it is."

The C-rank Gate marked on the map sat on prime land near a subway station in Bucheon. It was also one of those Gates blessed with what Hunters called "luck."

The monsters that appeared there were relatively easy to deal with compared to those in other C-rank Gates, and Magic Gems dropped frequently.

Im Kkeokjeong had worked as a Hunter in Bucheon for over ten years. There was no way either of us wouldn't know the Gate—or the name of the Guild that controlled it.

"This isn't exactly welcome news…"

The Skeleton King looked up from the smartphone he had been fiddling with at Kkeokjeong's low mutter.

"Humans. Where is this place that has you making such a fuss?"

I answered quietly.

"The place isn't the problem. The owner is."

"Hm? The owner?"

"That's right."

Gates couldn't be privately owned, but mid-sized Guilds and larger effectively controlled them through long-term leases.

And there wasn't a person in Korea—or anywhere else in the world—who didn't know the Guild that controlled the C-rank Gate at this address.

"Then who owns it?"

Kkeokjeong gave the Skeleton King a curt answer.

“Ares Guild.”

My eyes went to both of his arms before I could stop them.

The arms severed on someone’s orders had been reattached so cleanly you would never have known anything had happened. But they were trembling faintly, as though he remembered the pain.

“Uncle Kkeokjeong. No—hyung.[2597]”

“…I’m fine.”

The answer rang hollow. His trembling was growing worse, and his expression had darkened.

As if he’d noticed the look on my face, he made an effort to relax his own.

“I’m telling you, I’m fine. Now hurry up and go. If the magical power readings are skyrocketing, we could have another Mutated Gate on our hands.”

“…No. Those bastards can handle it themselves.”

How am I supposed to go? Not in this situation. Especially to help them, of all people.

I stood rooted to the spot. Kkeokjeong gave me a faint smile.

“Taekyung.”

“Yes?”

“I meant it when I said I’m fine. Everyone who cut off my arms, Lee Jungryong included, has paid for it. My rehabilitation’s practically finished, too. These days, I’m happy spending time with my wife and watching the kids grow up.”

“Hyung[2598]…”

“I’m really fine, so hurry up and go. There must be plenty of good people in Ares Guild, too. If you let a petty personal reason stop you from helping, you’ll regret it for a long time. At least, the Taekyung I know would.”

“…!”

“I’d like to help too, but I can’t. My rehabilitation isn’t quite done, and honestly, I’m not strong enough.”

He laughed heartily at his own forced joke. I watched him for a moment, then nodded.

He was right. The people facing danger inside the Gate weren’t enemies of mine or the Peace Guild.

If I sensed danger and possessed the strength to save someone from it, then stepping forward was the right thing to do.

That’s why we created the rescue team.

Maybe what I had to do had been decided the moment I obtained the System.

I gave Im Kkeokjeong a brief look of acknowledgment.

[2597] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[2598] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"I'll be back soon."

"All right. Don't get hurt."

"Deal with it quickly and return, you wicked human. As a reward, I shall show you this girl-group member's selfie."

I smiled warmly at the Skeleton King.

"Quit screwing around and follow me. Or I'll smash your smartphone as punishment."

"…Understood."

I should've done this from the start. You trying to get yourself killed?

By the time we reached the C-rank Gate *Orc Wasteland*, marked on Song Song's map, the area was full of frantic voices and shouting.

"The magical power readings are more than twice their usual level!"

"I know that. What about the request for backup?"

"N-Nothing yet!"

"Fuck, there have to be people left at the Bucheon branch! Tell them it's urgent and ask again for at least one A-rank Hunter!"

"We already passed that along, but most of the A-rank Hunters stationed in Bucheon are deployed overseas, and some of the others are on vacation, so they're refusing…"

"What? Vacation? They're refusing because they're on vacation? Those fucking—!"

It happened in an instant.

A fist filled with rage slammed into a parked car.

Bam!

With a thunderous crash, the foreign car worth more than a hundred million won[2599] crumpled, sending large and small fragments flying in every direction.

That was when the flushed, hard-breathing B-rank Hunter spotted the Skeleton King and me.

"Hell, this is driving me crazy. No matter how urgent things are, they should still be controlling access properly—"

His voice trailed off. His eyes went wide.

"Huh? Uh? Huh? Huhhhhh?"

Question after question spilled from his lips, his gaze fixed on my face. The Skeleton King snorted and opened his mouth with a meaningful expression.

"Heh heh. Yes, this human is *that* human."

"…?"

[2599] One hundred million won is about $71,000 or €65,000; the car is worth more than that.

Why is this bastard stepping in and making a scene when I'm just standing here?

I shot the Skeleton King a wary look and cleared my throat. Everyone who had been rushing around was now standing frozen, staring at us.

"Ahem. In case anyone here doesn't know who I am—"

"Jin Taekyung!"

"Lord Fuck!"

"Lord Sibu-leol!"

"…though I guess that won't be necessary."

I hated to say it myself, but at this point, I'd have to wonder if any Hunter who didn't recognize my face was actually a monster.

"Is that r-really Jin Taekyung?"

"I don't think he's a fake Jin Taekyung."

"Ah, that's not what I meant…"

"It's fine. That isn't important right now."

I turned to the B-rank Hunter who had smashed the car.

"From what I've seen, you seem to be in charge here. Am I right?"

"Y-Yes. I'm Gwak Hangu, Branch Leader of Ares Guild's Yeokgok Branch."

He wasn't even the Bucheon Branch Leader. He was one of the dozens of lower Branch Leaders beneath him, and he was a B-rank Hunter.

It reminded me just how large Ares Guild was—and how deep its talent pool ran. It also reminded me of something I'd briefly overlooked.

Maybe because of their public image, but the atmosphere here is better than I expected.

Ares Guild, the Peace Guild, and I had plenty of bad blood between us. But that fight had taken place beneath the surface. To people who knew nothing about it, everything above the surface looked calm.

No. If anything, the eyes of the Ares Guild members here held expectation and even goodwill.

Maybe we can build up our strength faster than Team Leader Choi expected.

But something more important needed my attention. I pushed the thought aside and spoke to the Branch Leader.

"Let's skip the rest and get straight to the point."

"Y-Yes?"

"Getting backup from the Guild is difficult, isn't it? Ares Guild has more than one or two Gates to look after, and you're sending people overseas too."

"Pardon?"

"Even if someone leaves now, they'll arrive too late. That A-rank Hunter on vacation probably has his phone and pager turned off while he enjoys himself.

And if the people here rush in, there's a good chance they'll die without rescuing anyone. Am I right?"

"W-We don't know that—"

"Come on. What we don't know is how long the people inside can hold out."

He gasped.

"It's been fifteen minutes since the readings first started rising. Your team members could be dying in there right now."

"W-Wait."

The B-rank Hunter barely managed to stop me before continuing in a trembling voice.

"I know. I know that too. But… letting an outsider intervene would be a serious violation of Guild policy."

"So?"

"Everyone here, including me, desperately wants to ask you for help. But we can't. You already know that. You've heard about it."

Anyone who worked as a Hunter had to know how strict and difficult Ares Guild's rules were.

Lee Jungryong had selected only the most capable Hunters from each rank and locked them inside a tall, enormous cage. The fact that no Guild would accept a Hunter expelled from Ares Guild wasn't some vague urban legend.

"Ha…"

"Fuck…"

Sighs and curses came from all around me. I looked at the Ares Guild members, then asked abruptly, "One person? Or two?"

"Huh? What are you—"

"I have a feeling two people have died while you've been hesitating."

"M-Mr. Jin Taekyung!"

"Hey, you by the measuring device. What's the reading now?"

A C-rank Hunter who had kept chewing his nails in front of the device even after I arrived answered with something close to a scream.

"Three times! It's passed three times the average magical power level!"

"…!"

Everyone there knew what that meant.

A Mutated Gate.

The third Mutated Gate to erupt in the week since the new year began.

I clicked my tongue softly and looked straight at the Branch Leader.

"What are you waiting for? Open it."

"…!"

“I wasn’t going to enter without the person in charge’s consent because it would be illegal. But people need to be saved, don’t they? So just say that I barged in while making a huge fucking scene and open it right now.”

He squeezed his eyes shut, his clenched fists trembling.

As I turned away from the silent Branch Leader, a trembling voice came from behind me.

“Let’s say… I gave my consent.”

I’d thought he was a complete moron. Maybe he was only a fool.

I let out a short laugh and left him with one final remark before striding toward the Gate.

“Call me if you get fired. The Peace Guild will take you in.”

Chapter 562

The wasteland stretched endlessly in every direction.

There was no sun, but a dark light made of magical power hung in the air. Hundreds of Orcs roamed in packs, hunted by the Hunters who came here.

Or rather, that was how it used to be.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

The ground trembled. The magical power saturating the wasteland swelled as though it might burst at any moment, squeezing the breath from their lungs.

The Hunters panted raggedly, their breath carrying a sickly sweet smell.

More than a hundred Orcs lay sprawled around them. The Hunters stood back-to-back in a circle, but beyond the bodies, a monster army ten times that size was advancing.

"T-Team Leader."

"Don't worry. We'll get out of here, whatever it takes."

The Team Leader's answer sounded hollow.

The one who had asked and the one who had answered both had some idea of the truth. None of them would leave this place alive today.

Even if they miraculously broke through the monster army's encirclement, there was one opponent they would never be able to bring down.

—Kraaaargh!

The Orc Lord.

At the roar of the powerful mutant said to be born only once in a million, more than a thousand Orcs shrieked and struck their weapons together.

—Chweeek!

Clang! Crash-crash-crash!

Despair flickered in the Hunters' eyes.

It's over.

Under the Orc Lord's command, the monster army had grown stronger. The Orcs were no longer a rabble roaming in groups of a few dozen, and the Hunters numbered fewer than twenty.

We can't win this.

The thought flashed through every mind at once.

It would have been no different even if they could overwhelm Hunters of the same rank. Their pride in belonging to Ares Guild crumbled before the death bearing down on them.

"…Damn Mutated Gate."

As someone muttered those words, the monsters filling the area began charging all at once.

At their head was the Orc Lord, the bastard they couldn't kill hard enough.

—Karchwi! Kalipto!

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Shouting something unintelligible in the Demon Realm language, its massive body hurtled toward them.

The raid Team Leader gritted his teeth, raised his shield, and charged to meet it. His team members called out from behind him, but he focused every ounce of strength and attention on the enemy ahead.

"Come on!"

It was a great shout, forced out to drive away his fear.

Red light flashed in the Orc Lord's eyes. The enormous ax in its hands came down toward the crown of the Team Leader's head.

Whooosh—crash!

One strike. That was all it took.

The blow was unbelievably fast and powerful. With a thunderous roar, it shattered the **Tower Shield** reinforced with high-grade enhancement magic. The Team Leader's eyes widened, the pain of his broken arms forgotten.

Whoooosh.

The ax had not touched him, but already it felt as though his side had been cut open.

His life flashed before his eyes, and the world slowed. A second blow was coming to split his body in two at the waist.

No. Not the second blow. The last.

The Team Leader closed his eyes. He had no desire to spend the final moment of his life looking at that ugly, fucking monster.

And in the next moment, along with the pitch-black darkness blocking his vision, a sharp sound of something cutting through the air pierced his ears.

Fwooooooosh—crack!

The pain he had been waiting for never came. It felt so strange that he wondered if this could really be death.

"…?"

The Team Leader cracked his eyes open and gaped.

Less than five paces away, the Orc Lord's three-meter-tall[2600] body stood motionless.

Its head was gone.

[2600] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

"…!"

"…!"

The world seemed to stop.

Humans and monsters alike stood frozen, staring. At that moment, only one thing moved across the endless wasteland.

Rrrrrr.

A single spear that had blown apart the Orc Lord's head, pierced through the ground, and now trembled violently.

The Hunters knew who owned that spear, with its soft, almost mystical glow.

Jin Taekyung!

Along with the name that flashed through their minds like lightning, the spear lodged deep in the ground shot upward and flew into someone's grasp.

Fwooooooosh—tap.

As though by agreement, they slowly turned their heads. Only then did they realize that the shadow of death looming over them had vanished without a trace.

"Little lambs wandering through the Mutated Gate. Run like fuck and get behind me."

Tap. Tap.

The middle-aged man walked with a confident, unhurried stride.

That did not change when he entered the skyscraper overlooking the Blue House[2601] and the National Assembly.

"If you're a Guild member, please show your access pass—"

"I haven't seen you before. New here?"

"Pardon? Yes, I am."

"Thought so. You must be new if you're acting like this. Looks like your Team Leader didn't tell you."

The Security Team Hunter, who had been staring blankly at the middle-aged man, sucked in a startled breath.

"Oh! I'm sorry. I didn't recognize you—"

"It's fine. I'm busy, so let me through."

"Y-Yes, sir."

The checkpoint that everyone, Guild member or outsider, had to pass through could not stop the middle-aged man. He glanced at the young Hunter bowing hurriedly to him and continued toward his destination.

[2601] The Blue House is the traditional name for South Korea's presidential office and residence.

A voice was already coming through the tiny communicator implanted beneath his ear in a simple operation.

“He’s waiting for you.”

The middle-aged man barely moved his lips.

“Where?”

“Section A.”

The skyscraper rose 150 stories, but Section A appeared on neither its building plans nor its signs. Only a tiny fraction of its countless Guild members were allowed into that space.

The middle-aged man was one of them.

“Have the Teleport ready.”

“It’s ready. By the way, that new Security Team recruit, Deputy Team—ah, sorry. Team Leader.”

“It’s fine. Don’t worry about it.”

Even I’m not used to it yet, so what can you expect?

Before he could finish the thought, the voice continued.

“In any case, I’ll inform the Security Team Leader and have the recruit disciplined.”

Not a report. Not a suggestion. A notification.

At some point, that had become normal, but it still felt strange to him. He frowned faintly.

“Do we really need to go that far?”

“Team Leader?”

“…Never mind. Handle it as you see fit.”

“Yes. I’ll deal with it appropriately.”

“Appropriately” meant a pay cut at minimum. It might mean a demotion.

He thought of the young man who had stopped him and felt a twinge of discomfort, but there was nothing he could do. That was the policy of the Guild he belonged to.

No. It was *their* policy.

And ever since that incident, it’s been getting worse.

He had long known that the Guild was ruled with an iron fist, but its grip had tightened even further since the recent unfortunate incident.

Perhaps the new king was impatient because his subjects had yet to fully accept his right to the throne.

The middle-aged man let out a small sigh and spoke as he walked.

“Update me on the VIP.”

“He’s in a bad mood.”

"Am I imagining things, or did you say the same thing yesterday?"

"Well… he read this morning's papers and—"

"That's enough. Send me everything the VIP is reading. Scrape it all and send it to me. Right now."

His magically secured smartphone vibrated as soon as he finished speaking. He tapped the screen lightly. The headlines of more than twenty morning newspapers that had left the presses only two or three hours earlier filled the display.

> Unprecedented Crisis… What Do the Successive Mutated Gates Signify?
>
> Ominous Signs: Will the Nightmare of China's Sichuan Province Come to Korea?
>
> Emergency Blue House[2602] Announcement: "We Have Signed an Agreement with the Peace Guild to Prevent Any Potential Crisis. Results So Far Are Encouraging."
>
> Third Mutated Gate, but Zero Fatalities? Worldwide Praise for the Peace Guild's Emergency Rescue Team.
>
> American Grand Mage Magic Johnson: "The Peace Guild Is a Beacon for a New Era. Jin and Choi Are Good, Upright Young Men."
>
> Former U.S. President Joseph Biden: "South Korea Is an Unquestionable Hunter Powerhouse, Home to Outstanding Young People Who Will Lead This Era. The Choi I Met Recently Is One of Them."
>
> Chinese Chairman Xiao Yang: "Mr. Choi Is Another Unsung Hero. We Remember How He Risked His Life Fighting in Sichuan."
>
> Japanese Prime Minister Shinjiro Koizumi Also Mentions Choi on Social Media: "As Far as I Know, Choi Is Korean. Therefore, He Is Not Japanese." Korean Netizens React: "Thank God He Isn't One of Our Idiots."
>
> Remarks by World Leaders Spark Unprecedented Interest: "Who on Earth Is This Choi?" Sources Identify Him as Peace Guild Team Leader Choi Minwoo…
>
> S-Rank Hunter Jin Taekyung to Attend New Year's "Communicating with the People" Press Conference with the President This Morning!
>
> …
>
> …
>
> …

"…Whew."

After reading them all, the middle-aged man rubbed his dry eyes. The fatigue he had forgotten came rushing back.

[2602] The Blue House is the traditional name for South Korea's presidential office and residence.

"Damn it."

"Have you finished reading?"

"Yes. I'd have been better off not reading them."

"I'm sorry to interrupt, but you should hurry."

"I was about to. I'm almost there."

Tap.

He stepped onto a faintly glowing magic circle. After he authenticated his fingerprint and infused the circle with mana, it recognized him and released a brilliant flash.

Flash!

A sensation like his entire body floating into the air seized him amid a dazzling halo of light.

The next moment, he opened his eyes and knew the Teleport to Section A had succeeded.

White marble and Magic Gems adorned the room. Around a dozen men and women in lightweight tailored suits bowed to him.

"Welcome, Team Leader."

Many people, speaking with one voice.

He glanced at the subordinates moving like machines and slowly stepped off the magic circle.

"Where's the VIP?"

"Alone in his private office."

"Without security? I clearly told you to keep at least three people stationed in the hallway—"

Boom!

A muffled crash from somewhere cut him off. He could guess what had happened and clicked his tongue.

"I'll go see him. Leave one person here and clear Section A."

"Yes."

His subordinates moved in perfect order as soon as he gave the command. Leaving them behind, he headed down the wide corridor.

At least fifty Magic Traps guarded it against intruders, but the access card around his neck concealed a device that let him pass safely through the minefield.

Bzzzt.

> **Head of Security Go Se-won**

A red glow swept past him, and the mana churning on every side settled instantly.

Go Se-won crossed the seemingly endless corridor with practiced ease and stopped before a firmly closed door.

Knock, knock.

“It’s Go Se-won.”

An irritable voice came from the other side.

“Come in.”

Go Se-won slowly took hold of the knob and pushed the door open.

The office looked as though a bomb had gone off. In the middle of the wreckage, a man sat on a sofa, staring at him with a red glow in his eyes.

“You’re later than usual.”

Go Se-won bowed his head without a word. Amid the scattered debris, a nameplate gleamed.

> **Ares Guild Vice Guild Master Go Jun**

Chapter 563

"You're later than usual."

Go Jun was wrong. Go Se-won's watch was always accurate, and there was still plenty of time before he was due at work.

The one who was different today wasn't Go Se-won. His superior was simply in an unusually foul mood.

Go Se-won bowed his head and kept his reply brief.

"I'm sorry."

"Enough. Sit down."

Being allowed to share Go Jun's sofa was a privilege reserved for his closest aides. But before Go Se-won could sit on the Italian leather, he realized his superior's anger was far from spent.

> "Go Hyeon-woo, Rough News."

The reporter, a man in his early thirties who had been given the floor, continued smoothly on the holographic TV.

> "Just ten days into the new year, we've already had three Mutated Gates. What are your thoughts on that, Mr. President?"

Go Se-won glanced to the side.

Go Jun's face was rigid, his eyes bloodshot. He was glaring at someone in the broadcast.

Ah.

Go Se-won remembered an article he had seen on his way in: Jin Taekyung and the President were holding an official New Year's press conference.

He had more or less guessed what was happening, but watching the broadcast in his current state was no different from forcing Go Jun to swallow deadly poison.

Like showing a snuff film to a child.

Go Se-won had made up his mind and was bending down to pick up the remote from the floor when—

"Head of Security."

Go Jun's sharp voice cut in. He kept his eyes on the TV.

"Leave it."

"…I'm only putting it back."

Go Se-won hesitated, brushed the glass shards off the remote, and set it on the table in front of the sofa. On the TV, a man in his early forties had begun to speak.

> “That’s a good question.”

He had a pleasant voice and a kind face, though there was nothing weak about him.

Baek Hanseong, Korea’s twenty-seventh President and the youngest ever elected at forty, continued in a gentle tone.

> “As those of you who saw the Blue House’s[2603] official announcement yesterday afternoon will know, these successive Mutated Gates…”

His calm, unflustered manner inspired trust. Baek Hanseong was known for speeches that held an audience with his voice and slipped in humor so subtly it was hard to tell whether he was joking. Of course people listened.

By the time his lengthy speech—almost like the one he had given when announcing his presidential campaign—ended, the reporters broke into vigorous applause.

“It’s a campaign rally in there.”

Go Jun spat out the words, anger and mockery mingling in his voice. Then he muttered,

“How many of those bastards haven’t taken our fucking money, huh?”

“…”

“They couldn’t even breathe properly when Master was around. The youngest president in history? Anti-Ares Guild? That bastard Baek Hanseong was still beneath Master’s feet in the end.”

Humiliation and rage poured from his voice—emotions that had never been visible in him before.

Go Se-won lowered his eyes. His thoughts turned cold.

It’s true. Though it’s all in the past now.

Lee Jungryong’s influence had been immense.

Even before Cheon Taemin vanished, he had taken little interest in worldly affairs, like an immortal above the clouds. Lee Jungryong had remained on the ground, enjoying a position equal to—or greater than—a president’s or king’s.

Yes. That was how it was back then…

Politicians, business leaders, even the masters of the great Guilds that had risen into a new ruling class had bowed to Lee Jungryong.

He was a hero who had accomplished extraordinary deeds at Cheon Taemin’s side. As the vanished savior’s sworn brother, entrusted with full authority, he had been all but a pope.

[2603] The Blue House was the presidential office of Korea.

Another Vatican.

The people of Korea called this 150-story skyscraper a second Blue House.[2604] In truth, it had been closer to the Vatican, where the pope lived.

Even people who freely cursed the incompetent government and lawmakers had been reluctant to speak against Ares Guild. Its name had been practically sacrosanct.

But…

> "This world! The entire world! Is changing even now! We have entered a new phase!"

As the President's voice rang out over unending applause, everything was changing.

With the fall of the giant that was Lee Jungryong, the shadow he had cast was beginning to lift.

And at the center of all these events, one person's presence was exerting a powerful influence.

> "But, my fellow citizens! The government and I will do everything in our power to keep you safe! Together with the young man seated beside me, we will protect Korea from every threat, at home and abroad!"

President Baek Hanseong did not say the young man's name. He didn't need to.

In the past few months, that man in his late twenties had become one of the most famous people in human history.

> "Waaaaah!"

> "Jin Taekyung! Jin Taekyung!"

> "Fuck! Fucking fuck!"

Cheers louder than any before shook the press conference hall.

The young man who had been sleeping with his chin propped at an angle suddenly opened his eyes. Then he began clapping at a frantic speed while staring at the President.

[2604] The Blue House was the presidential office of Korea.

> “That was truly an incredible speech, Mr. President. Especially your final words. They moved me so deeply that I feel—”

> “Um, that last part was about you, Hunter Jin Taekyung.”

> “Ah, wait a moment. My stomach really is churning. I think I’m suddenly getting motion sickness.”

> “All of this is being filmed. Please wipe the drool off your face first—”

> “Edit this out. Please. Okay?”

> “I told you several times before we started. We’re live.”

> “Right. Wow. Fuck, I’m screwed.”

> “It’s live. I said it’s live, please. Hunter Jin Taekyung. Hello?”

The sight of the sweating President in his forties and the young hero in his twenties was broadcast in its entirety.

It was a broadcasting accident that would go down in the history of Korean television, but no one would scold or curse Jin Taekyung for it.

Even now, the people caught on camera were not frowning. They were smiling as they chanted his name.

Jin Taekyung.

Watching them, Go Se-won realized that the young man and the crowd’s reaction to him resembled something he had thought of only moments ago.

…Sacrosanct?

Compared to the sun that was Cheon Taemin, Jin Taekyung was still only a torch.

But one thing was undeniable. Jin Taekyung was walking the same path as the man remembered as an immortal hero.

And perhaps, regardless of what Jin Taekyung wanted, everything around him was trying to make him a second Cheon Taemin.

> “Mr. Jin Taekyung! I heard you suppressed all three Mutated Gates that appeared this time by yourself! Would you say a few words about that?”

> “I wasn’t alone. There were two of us, though—”

> “Mr. Jin Taekyung! Kim Jin-mu, Mudang Daily!”

> “I have a question about the Mutated Gates!”

Reporters with microphones swarmed toward him. Camera flashes went off without pause.

Go Se-won listened to questions flying in from every direction and felt a sudden sense of déjà vu.

This is…

Something was wrong with the flow of it. It looked natural at first glance, but everyone was being drawn in a direction someone had chosen for them.

Then an unfamiliar reporter shouted a question, and a chill ran down Go Se-won’s spine.

> “I have a question about the third Mutated Gate you suppressed two days ago! According to information obtained by our newspaper, that Gate was being handled by a famous Guild—”

“…!”

That’s it. So that’s what this is.

The moment enlightenment flashed through him, Go Se-won hurriedly reached for the remote.

Crunch!

Go Jun crushed the remote and the table beneath it. His eyes flashed red.

“I’m sure I told you to leave it.”

“But, Vice Guild Master…”

“I won’t say it twice.”

The blood vessels in his superior’s eyes had burst. The voice that followed was so chilling that it raised goose bumps.

“Stay still. Unless you want to die.”

“Hk…!”

Go Se-won swallowed a breath without meaning to and leaned back against the sofa as though his half-raised body had collapsed.

On the holographic TV, exactly what he had feared was happening.

> “That’s right. Ares Guild handled that Gate. Well, it’s technically on a permanent lease, but as everyone knows, that’s practically ownership.”

The great Guilds’ monopoly on Gates was an open secret. Everyone knew; no one said it aloud.
Jin Taekyung had just exposed it without hesitation at a live, official Blue House[2605] press conference. And he wasn’t stopping there.

> “What exactly happened? The magical power readings kept climbing, and no rescue team came.”

The reporters lunged at their prey. Quite a few had once taken Ares Guild’s dirty money, but money always gave way to more money.

> “Wait. Are you saying a rescue team didn’t arrive even after you waited?”

Jin Taekyung nodded.

> “Yes. They still hadn’t come fifteen minutes after the initial situation began. In the meantime, the magical power readings kept rising until the Gate became a Mutated Gate.”

> “Does that mean it could have been dealt with before the Gate fully mutated if the rescue team had arrived on time?”

> “Well, I can’t be a hundred percent certain, but if they had sent in even one A-rank Hunter early on, there probably would have been a high chance of resolving it without outside assistance.”

> “Unlike the other Mutated Gates, the Guild responsible for this one has enormous numbers of Hunters and considerable financial resources. Why do you think it failed to send a rescue team in time?”

> “The reason… Well, I’m not sure.”

Jin Taekyung thought for a moment, then tossed out an answer as though it were nothing.

[2605] The Blue House was the presidential office of Korea.

> “That family seems to be having a lot of trouble these days. Or should I say, the boss? Their management has changed, too, so I imagine there was probably some confusion here and there.”

Crack!

Something beside Go Se-won splintered. He closed his eyes.

It’s over.

An enormous Guild with vast manpower and capital. A change in management.

Those two clues were enough. Anyone who knew anything would understand without searching online. Even if no one had named it yet…

> “It was a serious mistake, but what could I do? Fortunately, I happened to be there, so no one died. Personally, I’m just glad about that. Oh, and while I have this opportunity, I’d like to once again offer my deepest condolences to the deceased.”

> “An excellent answer, Hunter Jin Taekyung. I’m certain the deceased would be grateful and proud of you.”

Damn it.

Go Se-won swore inwardly and opened his eyes.

Korea’s youngest President had the microphone again. He was delivering the final blow.

> “Fortunately, we were able to bring this incident to an end without any fatalities, but our government intends to take the initiative and begin a thorough investigation. As President of Korea—and as a citizen—I find this Guild’s negligent response deeply regrettable. However, the wishes and legacy of the deceased, who was a great hero, have been passed on in their entirety to Hunter Jin Taekyung—”

The President’s words did not reach the end.

No—in precise terms, Go Se-won could no longer hear them.

“…!”

He threw up his guard on instinct. Powerful mana shot out like a beam of light, shattering the holographic TV and tearing through everything around it.

Kwa-gwa-gwa-gwang!

The layered protective magic circles installed by ten high-ranking mages broke apart. Bulletproof glass and everything else shattered, then scattered into dust.

At the center of the destruction stood Go Jun, his eyes blood-red.

“How dare you! How dare you! How dare you—!”

Bang! Bang! Kwaaaang!

Everything had a limit.

Those last words had set fire to all the anger Go Jun had swallowed in the days since becoming Vice Guild Master.

“I’ll kill him! I’ll kill him no matter what!”

Kwaaaang!

Go Jun was Lee Jungryong’s de facto successor. But those who watched today’s press conference would see it differently.

They would believe that Jin Taekyung was the new hero—and the only person who had inherited the will of Cheon Taemin, who had still not revealed himself, and Lee Jungryong, who had died only recently.

“Jin Taekyung! Jin Taekyuuung!”

Go Jun screamed the name as though coughing up blood, all reason gone.

Go Se-won watched him, his gaze sinking deep.

Chapter 564

When a company grows, what's the first thing it should do?

Everyone would answer differently, but every CEO has a dream tucked away somewhere in their heart.

Build a headquarters of their own.

Or should I call it an expansion in this case?

I was walking through the Guild House when I stopped and looked down at the work going on below.

"Hey, can somebody lift these materials with gravity magic?"

"All right, listen up. Any former tanks here? Hands up."

"Me."

"Over here, too. Why?"

"Why do you think? I'm putting you to work. Five F-ranks, over here. Bring an E-rank or two as well."

Grrrind. Boom!

Smooth marble rose and fell through the air, while every swing of the muscle-bound giants' sledgehammers smashed apart the solid concrete walls.

More than a hundred workers bustled about. They were all Awakened, which probably explained their astonishing pace.

Of course, their wages were astonishing too. But to a young tycoon with deep pockets, they were pocket change.

"The Guild House is getting cramped now that we have more people."

Team Leader Choi had dropped that remark a few days ago and immediately taken action.

I'd heard he bought up all the nearby land, paying above market value for it, and started a massive expansion. I wasn't going to argue.

It's not my money.

Besides, I had other uses for my own money.

My fifty trillion won[2606] in untaxed assets was shrinking bit by bit as I spent it, but what I'd used so far was a drop in the ocean compared to what remained.

Fifty trillion won[2607]…

Even thinking about it again, it was an absurd amount of money. Like the figure of a man gradually approaching from beyond the corridor.

Swoosh.

A huge man glided through the air like a ghost and spoke without warning.

[2606] Fifty trillion Korean won is about $36 billion or €32 billion at the project conversion rates.

[2607] Fifty trillion Korean won is about $36 billion or €32 billion at the project conversion rates.

"Hey, I watched the press conference."

"…?"

Wait. What are you doing here, hyung?[2608]

I stared at Magic Johnson in disbelief before I finally managed to speak.

"What is it?"

"Why?"

"Why? That's what I want to ask you. Why are you here again today?"

"I had something to take care of."

"You didn't come to use the bathroom, did you?"

"Of course not. I came to give Choi something. I figured I'd check on the progress while I was here."

"Do you put emails in your cereal and eat them?"

"You're not uncomfortable because I'm here, are you?"

"You didn't think I was comfortable, did you?"

Magic Johnson let out a heavy sigh at my immediate reply.

"Hey, Jin. Harsh words hurt sensitive people like me."

"…Hurt?"

I looked at his thick neck and iron-hard, bronze-colored arms.

He looks like a knife couldn't cut him.

Damn, that Black dude is jacked.

With a build like that, he could quit being a mage and become a melee Hunter right now.

I wasn't exaggerating, either. Search for "Magic Johnson's staff," and you'd get page after page of videos. Practically everyone knew the story of how he'd caved in an ogre's skull with a single blow from a staff made for casting magic. People in fitness communities were still arguing over how much the thing weighed.

And he's calling himself sensitive? Give me a break.

Magic Johnson caught the meaning of my lingering stare and shook his head.

"Not my body. My heart. The heart's what matters, Jin."

"Someone with a sensitive heart wouldn't have survived the Great Cataclysm. You're still alive and people call you a hero because you're strong."

"Hmm. I can't tell if that was a compliment or an insult."

"Take it as a compliment."

Magic Johnson gave me a suspicious look, then went on.

"Anyway, I watched the press conference. There was a lot to read into it."

The press conference…

[2608] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean term a man uses to address an older man, whether or not they are brothers.

I scratched the back of my head, embarrassed.

The official Blue House[2609] press conference I'd attended at the President's request had caused an enormous stir. I'd heard domestic viewership had topped seventy percent, and it had made headlines abroad too.

Even two days later, related searches were holding firm near the top of the real-time rankings. They'd probably still be there a week from now.

"The broadcast mishap probably helped, and the ratings were pretty good. I didn't know you watched it, Johnson."

"What you're up to is always news in the United States, Jin. President Baek's final words must have meant a great deal to certain people. Me included."

"Oh, that."

"I wondered why he was praising Mr. Lee so much. Then he landed one hell of a blow, didn't he?"

"Well, I wasn't the one who landed it… But I bet it got under Go Jun's skin."

We weren't living in the Warring States period,[2610] but anyone inheriting an organization that big still needed legitimacy.

And Go Jun, the new Vice Guild Master of Ares Guild, didn't have much of it.

"Ares Guild is a vast empire. Even if he inherited the shares according to the will, he didn't inherit all of Mr. Lee's influence. If they had shared blood, he would at least have met certain expectations in Asian society. But he doesn't, does he?"

"Lee Jungryong did have a son, but I heard he died young. He was an ordinary person who never Awakened, though, so he couldn't have succeeded Lee even if he were still alive."

Modern Guilds were like Murim sects. A bookish scholar couldn't become the Sect Leader of Huashan; a Guild Master needed the power and authority of a Hunter.

Magic Johnson knew that as well as anyone. He nodded.

"True. Sseokkochoon, on the other hand, has the skill, whatever his faults as a person. I heard he passed the S-rank Hunter qualification assessment with an incredible score. The news got buried almost immediately under everything else that's been happening, of course."

"His name is Go Jun, not Sseokkochoon. And anyway, that bastard was Lee Jungryong's Head of Security."

"That's nowhere near enough. He needs the support of the other founding heroes who made Ares Guild what it is today. But…"

"He didn't have time."

"Exactly. Time. Mr. Lee probably wrote that will to prepare for the worst without ever imagining he'd die so easily."

[2609] The Blue House is the traditional name for South Korea's presidential compound.

[2610] The Warring States period was an era of competing states in ancient China, from the fifth to the third century BCE.

But he had died in the end, and Go Jun had inherited the crown before he could firmly establish himself as the successor.

Being Head of Security was proof that he had been one of Lee Jungryong's closest aides, but there were many difficulties involved in inheriting an enormous organization like Ares Guild.

Even with Lee Jungryong's will, it would not be easy for elderly veterans to respectfully serve a fresh-faced man in his thirties as their superior.

On top of that, Go Jun himself had rapidly fallen apart since Lee Jungryong's death.

And in the middle of all that, his legitimacy was openly denied during an official Blue House[2611] press conference with seventy percent viewership…

President Baek Hanseong's remark had been both subtle and sharp.

He had indirectly criticized Ares Guild over the Mutated Gate while praising Lee Jungryong's achievements and presenting me as the man who would carry on his legacy.

The whole thing was staged.

The press conference had been a joint production by President Baek Hanseong, who had shown an anti-Ares stance since his days as a lawmaker, and Team Leader Choi.

They'd won over reporters, fed them questions, and steered the conversation where they wanted it to go. The script and cast had been prepared from start to finish.

If Lee Jungryong had still been alive, they would have scrapped the plan. But Go Jun lacked the power to put down the new underdog's rebellion, so we finished the shoot without a hitch—with a domestic rating of seventy percent and the foreign press shining its spotlight on us.

"Either way, it's another small victory. We should have a glass of champagne. Where's Choi?"

"He was busy before, but lately he's been swamped. If we're lucky, he might be in his office."

"He's not."

Magic Johnson shrugged.

"I just stopped by there on my way here."

"Ah. Something else must have come up."

That was nothing new. Team Leader Choi might have held a team leader's title, but he'd effectively been the Guild Master from the start. By now, the public saw him that way too.

He was probably one of the busiest people in Korea.

"Hey, Jin. Want to walk with me?"

[2611] The Blue House is the traditional name for South Korea's presidential compound.

"Sure. As long as we stay away from secluded spots."

"You've gotten funnier."

"…"

"…Tell me that was a joke."

I walked faster without answering. Magic Johnson followed, stepping through the air as if he were floating, and grumbled.

"Jin, why do you keep making me out to be some kind of weirdo?"

"Because you keep saying weird things."

"I'm joking, obviously. Besides, I have preferences. You're not my type. That guy over there, maybe."

I followed his gaze to a tall, handsome man walking past.

"I haven't seen him before. New Guild member?"

"Someone might mistake you for a member of our Guild. How many people here do you even know?"

"That's ridiculous! You think I wouldn't remember a handsome man like that?"

"…"

Why is he so adamant about it?

He had an uncanny eye for this sort of thing. I sighed and answered.

"I don't really know his name, but he is new. C-rank, I think?"

"I don't know who his former Guild Master was, but he must be crying tears of blood. With looks like that, he'd draw plenty of attention. He could do well as a star Hunter."

"His former Guild Master is probably crying blood over something else. He was humiliated at the press conference."

"Oh. Then was he…?"

"Yeah. He used to belong to Ares Guild."

Leaving Ares Guild for Peace Guild meant more than a simple transfer. Magic Johnson seemed to understand.

"Living proof that the impregnable fortress is starting to shake. How many have come over from Ares so far?"

"Not many. Around ten."

"The number isn't the point. It proves a crack has opened."

I gave a small nod. If outsiders could see the crack, it was probably much bigger on the inside.

Of course, we can't rule out the possibility that Go Jun sent him deliberately as a spy.

That was why he had been accepted only after a thorough verification process, and I heard they planned to deploy him in actual operations little by little.

Even with the System, I couldn't read people's minds. Team Leader Choi's intelligence network would be a great help there.

"What's that place?" Magic Johnson asked. "The security looks serious."

I'd been walking in silence, lost in thought. I looked up and saw the titanium-alloy door he was pointing at.

"Oh, that? It's a training room."

"The training room? A training room?"

"Yeah."

"My goodness. What kind of training room needs security like that?"

Magic Johnson gave an incredulous laugh.

"Five overlapping spells? I can understand not wanting anyone to watch you train, but isn't that excessive inside a Guild House?"

"Who knows?"

I kept my answer short. The room had been prepared for only a handful of people.

More specifically…

For people training in the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique.

I hadn't even told Magic Johnson about it. Access was limited to Team Leader Choi, Butler Kim, Song Song, and Im Kkeokjeong.

"Judging by the security, it doesn't seem like a space open to every Guild member."

I nodded at his observation.

"That's exactly right. It's for the Guild's founding members, including me."

"Hmm. A secret, then. Now you've awakened my curiosity as a mage."

"Put it back to sleep."

"That's cruel. I can't even take a quick look?"

I hesitated, then waved him off.

"No. Someone's inside."

"Who? Choi?"

"No."

A sudden bitterness came over me.

"Someone who needs to train more desperately than anyone."

"…?"

"There is someone like that."

I couldn't see him now, but I could picture him clearly: a middle-aged Hunter training over and over, sweat pouring off him like rain. He tried harder than anyone to act as though he was fine, even as he willed himself back onto his feet with his spirit brutally crushed.

Maybe it's time to start that…

The thought that flashed through my mind slowly took shape as Magic Johnson spoke again.

"Can't be helped. Give this to Choi when you see him."

“Huh? Give him what?”

“This.”

Swoosh.

A small object slipped inside my clothes on a faint current of qi.

I felt the chip and looked up. The Grand Mage’s face had turned grave.

“It’s not just Korea and the United States. Magical power readings are soaring all over the world. Up seven percent from last year. That lucky number has never felt so ominous.”

“…!”

Chapter 565

After Magic Johnson left, I texted Team Leader Choi, who still wasn't answering his phone, then headed straight for my private office on the top floor of the Guild House.

Bang.

Hearing the door slam shut behind me, I dropped heavily onto the floor.

The place was over a hundred pyeong, but all it held was a small desk and a single chair.[2612] It was called an office. Really, it was a training ground.

I immediately took out my smartphone and inserted the chip.

Click.

The latest model I'd bought recently had every feature imaginable, including holographic video playback, which had become common over the past decade or so.

Bzzzz.

Light spilled from the phone's projector with a faint hum. I quickly used Seizing an Object Through Empty Space to draw the blackout curtains, then focused on the footage filling the dark office.

Crackle. Crackle.

Static.

Boom! Kraaang!

A deafening roar.

Shrieeeek!

A monster's cry.

"Aaaah!"

A human scream.

It all mingled before my eyes, then scattered. The place, lined with tents and buildings of every size, had become a horrific battlefield.

Mutated Gate.

The words flashed through my mind.

Then—

"In the name of Allah!"

"Waaaaah!"

A group in military caps and turbans charged forward, shouting at the top of their lungs. They looked Arab, and their bodies were soaked in someone else's blood.

There was even a child among them, no older than an elementary school student.

A child…

[2612] A pyeong is a Korean unit of area equal to about 3.31 m^2 (35.6 ft^2).

There was no way these people were regular soldiers. Their mismatched clothing had already told me as much. They had to be Arab rebels—the kind who had stained the Middle East with blood even before the Great Cataclysm.

Then, the next moment—

“Aaaah! G-God is great!”

Along with the terrified cry of a little boy, countless firearms in their hands opened fire.

Rat-tat-tat-tat!

Whoosh! Boom!

Enough firepower to riddle ordinary humans with holes poured out at once. But their enemies were neither ordinary nor human.

Kraaang!

A huge blaze rose from the explosion. The rebels stood panting as black smoke filled the area. Then the smoke parted, and a flash of light cut through it.

Whoosh. Shing!

One strike was enough. Dark red magical power swept outward in a crescent, cutting through everything in its path.

Necks, waists, chests. The wounds differed, but the result was the same.

Death.

Splaaash!

A beat later, fountains of blood stained the sand red.

The surviving rebels stared wide-eyed at the grisly deaths of nearly twenty comrades.

“M-Masoud!”

“My God…”

But their god neither appeared nor answered his followers. In his place came a monster clad from head to toe in green armor.

Chirr. Chiriririk.

A triangular head. Two quivering antennae. Forelegs curved like scythes.

It was a mantis, enormous enough to look down at a grown man. Powerful magical power radiated from its body, which bore not a scratch from the rebels’ attack.

“G-Giant Mantis…”

Someone groaned the name. The huge foreleg swept through the air again.

Whoom. Shing!

A rebel frozen in place split down the middle. Magical power shot from the foreleg like an arrow, tearing through everything around it.

Shing! Shing! Kraaang!

People. Weapons. Even the tanks hastily sent into battle could not stop it.

Explosions and screams rang out as the attacks cut in every direction. Before long, there were five Giant Mantises, and they leaped among the humans.

Chit-chit-chit!

Chiriiit!

Crack! Splaaash!

With every strange cry, limbs flew from the roughly hundred rebels, and blood sprayed across the sand.

Those who fought while calling on their god and those who fled in terror alike fell in the desert, never to rise again.

“Aaah! Aaaaah!”

Shunk!

A scythe-like foreleg slashed through the rebel’s back and shattered his breastbone.

Having struck down the last rebel still resisting, the Giant Mantis suddenly turned. A red eye protruding from the side of its head fixed on the camera.

It found the camera.

It saw the camera, and I saw it.

Then, just as the Giant Mantis sensed something strange and cautiously began approaching the camera—

“May the flames of God descend upon this place. Fire Rain!”

Fwoosh!

An aged voice rang out. At the same instant, dozens of fireballs formed from mana came hurtling over the Giant Mantis’s shoulder like meteors.

Chiririririt!

It shrieked and swung a foreleg at them.

Boom!

The impact dyed the screen—no, everything around it—red. Dozens of Hunters appeared in the distance and raced across the battlefield through the bursting fireballs.

“Allahu Akbar!”

“God is great! Kill every one of those devils!”

Krrk, chiiit!

Humans and monsters. Monsters and humans.

The two sides began killing each other again. But I couldn’t watch the battle to its end.

Crackle. Crackle. Pop!

In an instant, the hologram filling the room vanished amid a burst of heavy static.

“…Whew.”

I let out the breath I'd been holding and picked up the phone I'd set aside. The list on the chip held more than twenty videos I hadn't watched yet.

Fuck. How long has it been since the last batch? And there's already more.

Worldwide magical power readings had risen seven percent over the previous year.

Some idiots might call that *only* seven percent. But a drop of even a few percentage points in the air's oxygen concentration would cause an uproar. This was proof that things were going to hell.

No. Maybe…

This could be the beginning of the second Great Cataclysm.

As I watched the remaining videos one by one, my fears began to take shape.

Europe. The Middle East. West Africa. Southeast Asia… What is this, some kind of worldwide festival?

Changes were already happening all over the world at once.

A new Gate appeared among the green hills of Switzerland, where I could picture Patrache running around with a dog biscuit in his mouth.[2613] Elsewhere, rebels and regular soldiers rained shells on each other while monsters poured from low-rank Gates left unattended.

A few places had been prepared well enough to suppress the outbreaks early. In more than half the videos, though, the monsters were defeated only after causing considerable damage.

This…

I kept replaying the footage, my brow furrowing. The damage wasn't simply due to poor Gate defenses.

But insight wasn't the only thing that came to me then.

Ding.

I heard the faint chime of the elevator, followed by the presence of two people drawing closer. Recognizing my uninvited guests, I reached out.

Fwoosh.

A warm breeze swept through the room. Qi flowed from my palm and gently pushed the door open, revealing familiar faces.

"What took you so long? I texted you ages ago."

"I'm sorry. I couldn't be reached for a while."

I'd been about to lay into the latecomers, but I tilted my head.

"Couldn't be reached? Did you go into a Gate or something?"

"Something like that."

"…Either you did or you didn't. What's 'something like that' supposed to mean?"

[2613] Patrache is the dog in *A Dog of Flanders*.

"Butler Kim and I had somewhere to stop. It was important, so it couldn't be helped."

Team Leader Choi stepped inside as he answered. Butler Kim followed, closed the door, and gave me a slight nod.

Haven't seen him in a while.

Butler Kim had hardly shown his face at the Guild lately. What important business had the two of them been handling?

It had been about a week since I'd seen him, and the question lingered. But something more urgent needed our attention. Team Leader Choi knew it too.

"We can discuss this later. For now, we should check the information Mr. Johnson gave us."

"Oh. Here."

I played the footage again. By the time they'd gone through every video and the attached materials, both their faces had hardened.

"Worldwide magical power readings up seven percent?"

Butler Kim's usually gentle voice came out cracked.

"Young Master."

"Yes. It's progressing faster than we expected. This is serious."

Seven percent wasn't merely a rise. *Surge* was closer to the mark.

And that sharp change in magical power levels was especially obvious in the footage.

"The monsters…"

I nodded and finished Team Leader Choi's thought.

"Yeah. They've gotten fucking strong."

Rising magical power readings meant stronger monsters. The Giant Mantis in the first video had held its own even after taking a hit from Fire Rain.

It was like watching Chikorita get a tan from Charizard's flames.[2614]

Type advantages were supposed to mean something. But as magical power readings climbed, the monsters were growing strong enough to shrug those advantages off.

In a situation this fucked, places that kept their precious Hunters deployed in minimal numbers as a precaution were bound to be overwhelmed.

To sum it up…

"We're fucked. It's five minutes to a complete shitshow."

Things were moving at a ridiculous pace. Keep this up, and monsters might be part of the weather forecast by the end of the year.

[2614] Chikorita and Charizard are Pokémon. Chikorita is a Grass-type, which is vulnerable to Charizard's fire.

A pretty weathercaster would point to a map of the Korean Peninsula no bigger than a booger and explain it all:

"Tomorrow, goblins are expected to fall in Cheorwon, Gangwon Province, instead of heavy snow. They're expected to pile up to a height of twenty meters, so residents should grab their shields and antidotes and evacuate immediately."[2615]

"…"

Fuck. Heavy snow is annoying enough. Now monsterfall? Seriously?

Just imagining monsters pouring down from the sky made my heart shrivel.

Of course, I wasn't going to sit around twiddling my thumbs until then. I had to stop Korea from turning into Hell Peninsula, whatever it took.[2616]

I'd kept this possibility in mind, but… it's definitely happening too fast.

I'd thought we had a little more time. The prospect of bringing forward *that thing* —the plan I'd been working on little by little since Murim—weighed on me.

That was when Team Leader Choi spoke.

"At this point, we can't keep it hidden any longer."

He turned off the hologram. His voice was low.

"It's already beyond what can be concealed at a national level. The longer we wait to tell people, the worse the confusion will be."

This wasn't a wave that would pass. It was a tsunami that might sweep whole cities away.

"What are you planning to do, Team Leader Choi?"

"Gate defenses come first right now. We need a breakwater before the tsunami hits."

"Strengthen the Gate defenses?"

"That will leave us with fewer Hunters for raids, and we won't be able to make full use of all the Gates Peace Guild owns. But I know which matters more."

"That's a relief."

I let out a quiet laugh. Team Leader Choi knew where to draw the line. He had grand ambitions of swallowing Ares Guild, but he also knew when to push forward and when to stop.

That's the biggest difference between him and Lee Jungryong.

"Then we should focus on the Gates for now. It's unfortunate, but we'll have to put matters concerning Ares Guild on hold for a while…"

"Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Yes?"

Team Leader Choi's clear eyes were fixed on me.

[2615] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

[2616] "Hell Peninsula," or *Hellbando*, is Korean slang portraying life in Korea as harsh or oppressive.

“I said that I would make Gate defenses my top priority. I never said I would put matters concerning Ares Guild on hold.”

“…!”

What?

My eyes widened. Team Leader Choi went on.

“I told you I had important business to take care of.”

“Then that important business was…?”

“A major figure in Ares Guild. A war hero who helped my maternal grandfather bring the Great Cataclysm to an end. Once the friend Lee Jungryong trusted most. And now the leader of the largest faction within Ares threatening Go Jun.”

His voice was gentler than ever, with thorns hidden beneath it.

“Everything crumbles from the inside.”

Chapter 566

What Team Leader Choi told me was the last thing I'd expected.

If magical power readings hadn't been rising so sharply, I might have found this even more interesting.

A traitor?

A few Ares Guild members had come over to our side after the recent incident, but those were ordinary transfers. Rank-and-file Guild members like them were a dime a dozen at Ares.

A traitor on the inside was another matter.

Especially if he's a big shot.

In Murim terms, he was a master of the previous generation. Having lived through the Great Cataclysm already made him interesting enough, but he was also the head of an internal faction powerful enough to threaten Go Jun.

Oh, now that's appetizing.

"…Mr. Jin Taekyung?"

"Oh. Yes? What is it?"

"Here, take this first."

It was a handkerchief. I blinked at him, and Team Leader Choi pointed awkwardly at my chin.

"I don't know why, but there's a lot of drool around your mouth."

"…Oh."

"It looks like it's about to dr—ugh."

What was with the *ugh*? A man could drool a little.

I wiped my mouth with my sleeve and got straight to the point.

"So who is he? The traitor."

"Traitor. I doubt he'd like hearing that. How should I put it… He'd probably prefer to be called a business partner. Or Ares Guild's next Vice Guild Master."

"What kind of bullshit is that? It sounds like you've more or less struck a deal with him already. If it looks like betrayal, I'm calling him a traitor. Is he just telling himself otherwise to feel better?"

Team Leader Choi wasn't the one who answered.

Butler Kim had been listening quietly. Now he spoke in a low voice.

"He craves honor."

"Honor?"

"As people grow old and death draws closer, they often begin to cling to honor. No… Looking back on the life he's led, *greed* might be the better word."

Had I ever heard Butler Kim speak so harshly about anyone?

Lee Jungryong was the only person who came to mind. But what Butler Kim had shown Lee was anger. What he felt toward this man sounded more like contempt.

He almost never shows his feelings this openly.

From everything I'd seen and heard, Butler Kim was practically up there with Jesus and Buddha. Sure, he seemed to have had a fiery temper when he was young, but that was a long time ago.

Who the hell is this guy?

Judging by how severely he was criticizing the man's entire life, they clearly knew each other well. But there were so many Ares Guild executives who wielded considerable influence that no name immediately came to mind.

As if he'd read my mind, Team Leader Choi spoke.

"Director Song. Song Cheonwoo is that kind of man."

"Song Cheonwoo. Song Cheonwoo…"

The name sounded vaguely familiar. I searched for it on my phone and found a short profile.

Calling it a profile was generous. It had his date of birth, a few lines about his life, and two photos of the same man side by side at the top of the page, one from his younger days.

Still, it gave me something.

"Huh? Wait, is this guy…?"

"Have you seen him before?"

"I think so. There's a framed picture of him in the hallway at the Hunter training center. Isn't there?"

"You probably remember correctly. He briefly served as head of the Hunter training center a little over twenty years ago."

"Oh."

That was before the rules for the position had been properly established, but even then, only a top ranker with an impressive record could become head of the Hunter training center.

He really is a big deal.

For someone with his reputation, though, there was barely anything about him online. A man like this had to have plenty of accomplishments and stories to his name, yet his biography was only two or three lines long. His profile hadn't even been updated in three years.

Three years ago?

Even a B-list celebrity would have more written about them. I frowned and tapped around for another source.

Bzz.

My phone vibrated faintly. A notification appeared on the screen.

> **Team Leader Choi**
> └ **Team Leader Choi:** *[File attached]*

“What’s this all of a sudden?”

“I thought it would be faster. I doubt you’ll find much detail about him through an Internet search.”

“Come on. In this day and age?”

“Then I’ll delete the attachment.”

“But since you went to the trouble of sending it, I’ll read it.”

“…”

“Listen until someone finishes speaking Korean.”

Having offered Team Leader Choi that valuable advice, I opened the file. Unlike the online profile, it ran to dozens of pages.

I started taking in the information on the screen as fast as I could.

Name: Song Cheonwoo. Age: seventies.

He was an A-rank Hunter, naturally. Twenty years ago, he’d ranked as high as third in Korea. The two people ahead of him had been Cheon Taemin and Lee Jungryong, which told me he was a formidable fighter in his own right.

During the Great Cataclysm, he’d taken part in dozens of major battles. His work had apparently been more prominent overseas than at home: he’d received medals from eight countries, including the United Kingdom, Germany, and France.

And the rest of his career? There was too damn much to go through line by line.

“That’s some résumé. How did I not remember him?”

“He isn’t as well known in Korea as you might think. Most of his notable work was overseas, and he spent very little time working here after the war.”

“Ah. Right.”

His stint as head of the Hunter training center stood out, but according to the file, he’d resigned voluntarily before serving even half of his four-year term.

The official reason was his health, but…

“Two months later, appointed Director of Ares Guild’s European regional branch.”

I read the line aloud. Team Leader Choi nodded.

“That was his last position here. From twenty years ago until now, he’s remained the Director of Ares’s European regional branch. That’s why younger Hunters like you and me know so little about him.”

“Leave yourself out of it. You probably know Song Cheonwoo better than almost anyone. Am I wrong?”

“What makes you think so?”

"Who do you take me for, an idiot? Cheon Tae—sorry. Anyway, you seem to have quite a connection with that person, and Butler Kim knows him too, so there has to be a link. To give one more example…"

"What would that be?"

I didn't have to think long. I pulled up a fairly recent memory and tossed out a phrase.

"Director of the European regional branch."

"…!"

"You told me that when you were at Ares, they kept shuttling you between overseas branches. I think Europe was one of them."

A faint smile touched Team Leader Choi's lips. I'd got it right.

"You remembered."

"I keep telling you I'm not that stupid."

"You're right. Song Cheonwoo followed my maternal grandfather long before I was born. When I was assigned to the European branch five years ago, Song used his authority as Director to keep me close."

"So did you know each other personally…?"

"On second thought, 'keep me close' isn't the right expression. I should say he kept me under surveillance and isolated me."

"…So you weren't close at all. Got it. Go on."

"From what I saw of him, Song Cheonwoo's abilities don't match the scale of his ambition. Though his rival at the time may simply have been too formidable."

His rival? I didn't have to think about that one.

"Lee Jungryong."

"A mountain can have only one master. Even if they were once friends, one of them had to leave."

Now it made sense. Why a man of Song Cheonwoo's stature had left Korea so soon after the war. Why he'd spent twenty years stuck in an impressive-sounding post overseas.

He was demoted.

There was no other way to put it. Lee Jungryong had won their power struggle inside Ares Guild and exiled his rival to Europe. Over time, Song had faded from people's memories.

No. Knowing Lee Jungryong, he'd made sure Song was *forgotten*.

Which means this file…

It wasn't a collection of Internet gossip. Experts had compiled and polished this investigation. It went beyond research and came close to surveillance.

So that's why he sent it separately.

Unlike the online profile, whose updates had stopped five years ago, the final page of the file dealt with recent events.

- **November 15, 2046.** Discussed retirement at a party hosted by the British ambassador. Audio file attached.
- **November 28, 2046.** Purchased a two-story mansion of approximately 300 pyeong[2617] in Samseong-dong, Seoul. Appears intended as a residence after retirement.
- **January 1, 2047.** Arrived through Incheon International Airport. Met secretly with key members of Ares Guild's board of directors. Exact number and names attached in supplementary materials.
- **January 2, 2047.** Attended Lee Jungryong's funeral. Held a second meeting with major political and business figures and key members of the Guild.
- **January 4, 2047.** Ares Guild's board held an official meeting to appoint a Vice Guild Master. Go Jun's appointment was approved after three revotes.

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The file was packed with information on Song Cheonwoo's movements over the past two months. Just reading it, I could see exactly how his thinking had changed.

"Song Cheonwoo's got his heart set on a comeback."

Team Leader Choi nodded.

"In November, he subtly expressed his intention to resign in a private setting, and he even purchased a mansion in Korea where he could stay after retirement. But…"

"Lee Jungryong died."

"Yes. No one could have expected that. To a man on the verge of retirement, it must have looked like one last chance."

"And his opponent wasn't Lee Jungryong anymore. It was Go Jun. With you on his side, he must have thought he could win."

Go Jun had needed three revotes to secure the Vice Guild Master position. That alone was proof. Song Cheonwoo, seventy-something and about to retire, had been gathering support wherever he could for one last shot.

"Pretty energetic for a man his age."

Team Leader Choi gave a quiet laugh.

"That's the magic of power, isn't it? It's given me an opportunity too."

"Sure. That's all well and good, but…"

What was this feeling? My mouth felt gritty, as though I'd chewed a handful of sand.

[2617] *Pyeong* is a Korean unit of area equal to 3.31 m² (35.6 ft²). About 300 pyeong is 990 m² (10,700 ft²).

I stared at Song Cheonwoo's face on the screen. Then Team Leader Choi spoke softly beside me.

"And if this works… a grandparent and grandchild[2618] may finally see each other again after a long time."

What hand?

I blinked at him. A moment later, I understood.

"No way."

The savior of the twenty-first century. The immortal hero who had saved humanity and would live forever in its memory—yet had vanished one day behind an invisible curtain.

Cheon Taemin.

He hadn't shown himself even when his only blood relative was in danger. Not even after Lee Jungryong died.

And his maternal grandson, born of the hero's blood, spoke with the smile gone from his face.

"Song Cheonwoo knew where my maternal grandfather was."

Go Se-won, the Head of Security, gazed at the teacup in front of him.

The cup, once warm, had gone cold. Tea-leaf dregs floated in the little tea he'd deliberately left behind.

Looks just like me.

He'd been staring at the cup for over an hour since making his report. At this point, he was almost getting attached to it.

But there was nothing else he could do. His job was to report the facts as they were, not to give orders. And considering the gravity of what he'd reported, he was fortunate his superior hadn't smashed everything around him as he had last time.

He's thinking it over. The longer he thinks, the better the decision should be.

His superior's next words proved how badly he'd misjudged the situation.

"Kill him."

"Sir?"

"I said kill him. His children. His grandchildren. His daughters-in-law. All of them."

Thud.

A file folder slipped off the table, struck the floor, and fell open.

Go Jun stared at the three Korean characters spelling *Song Cheonwoo*, then at the photograph of a man with prominent cheekbones. Fire flickered in his eyes.

[2618] The Korean word *joson* means a grandparent and grandchild. Its final syllable sounds like *son*, the Korean word for "hand."

“Has this old bastard gone senile…?”

Chapter 567

“Has this old man gone senile…?”

Go Se-won had lost count of how many times he’d faced those red eyes.

Go Jun’s gaze had gone beyond ominous. It was chilling now, and Go Se-won swallowed before he realized he was doing it.

But he was the Head of Security.

He was the only person who could put the brakes on Go Jun’s rampage, if only for a moment. And after all that deliberation, his superior was about to make a disastrous move. Go Se-won had a duty to talk him out of it.

“Vice Guild Master.”

Go Jun looked at him. A chill ran down Go Se-won’s spine, but he managed to speak.

“What you just said… Were you serious?”

Go Jun frowned.

“Of course not. Do I look like that much of an idiot to you, Team Leader Go?”

“Oh.”

Go Se-won had waited for the answer with a sinking feeling, so he let out a quiet sigh of relief.

Come to think of it, the idea was absurd.

Go Jun had grown far more violent lately, but surely he wouldn’t order every member of Song Cheonwoo’s family killed…

“Don’t kill them. Capture them and bring them here.”

“Excuse me?”

“Didn’t you hear me?”

Of course he had.

Go Se-won was an A-rank Hunter who could hear a mosquito’s wings flutter from ten meters[2619] away.

He asked again because he’d heard something he would rather not have heard at all.

“Would you repeat that, please?”

Bang! Crack!

The table, replaced only a few days ago, was smashed to pieces again. Flames blazed in Go Jun’s eyes.

“I said bring them here. I don’t care if it’s the grandchild Song Cheonwoo fusses over every day or some white grandmother he met at a retirement community in Europe. Anything I can use to get a grip on that old man’s life!”

[2619] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

His shout rang through the room, the veins standing out on his neck. Then his voice dropped.

"So, Team Leader Go. Send the men out and bring them here. Now."

"…!"

"What? Didn't you hear me this time either?"

There would not be a third warning.

Realizing that there was nowhere left to retreat, Go Se-won lowered his head slightly.

"No, sir. I heard you clearly."

"Then get moving. Ah, where did you say that old man's family lived?"

"On the outskirts of London. The whole family lives together in a huge mansion converted from a castle."

A life worthy of European nobility.

Song Cheonwoo had been able to live that way after losing the power struggle within Ares because Lee Jungryong had allowed it and supported him.

Old affection between friends? Mercy? To Lee Jungryong, those words were about as useful as cabbage.

He could afford to look down on a rival several moves behind him. That arrogance was the ease of a man with overwhelming power.

He kept his only political rival completely under his thumb. His successor's first thought is to kidnap the man's family.

It came down to temperament. To the difference in what each man was made of.

Go Se-won pushed the thought from his mind and continued.

"There are about thirteen of them, counting his children, their spouses, and his grandchildren. Some of the grandchildren commute to school by helicopter or Teleportation magic circle. We receive updates on their locations in real time."

"You've taken measures? Since when?"

"Since he entered the country. I reported it at the time, but you seemed extremely busy, so I took care of it on my own authority."

"You're good at your job, Team Leader Go. I thought you'd lost your touch after getting married."

"…Thank you."

Praise and a jab in the same breath. Go Se-won bowed his head again. Go Jun looked down at him, then muttered in a cold voice.

"Come to think of it, what an ungrateful old man. He should have thanked me for letting him keep his position this long. And he stabs me in the back?"

Song Cheonwoo should have retired before the new year.

But the Monster Wave in China and Lee Jungryong's death had rekindled the ambition the old lion had never quite abandoned. The hyenas caught its scent and quietly lined up behind him.

The influential members of the elder generation, just before a sweeping change of generations.

They were the pack of hyenas.

"Damn old bastards."

Go Jun sprang to his feet and began pacing. Then he spoke again.

"What about him?"

Him.

He hadn't said a name, but Go Se-won knew immediately whom he meant.

The greatest threat wasn't the old lion leading the hyenas. It was the young male lion prowling the grassland beyond Ares Guild's high fences, waiting for his chance.

"Choi Minwoo has returned to Peace Guild."

"You're certain he met that old man, Song Cheonwoo?"

Go Se-won answered at once.

"They met in secret and concealed themselves with advanced illusion magic, but yes. We're certain."

"What about Director Hong? Can we trust him?"

Director Hong was one of the elders who, like Song Cheonwoo, had been approaching honorary retirement. He was also the helpful informant who had told them about today's meeting.

Go Se-won nodded.

"Yes. He read the situation quickly."

"He's always been quick on the uptake. Still, don't let your guard down. He's known Song Cheonwoo for over thirty years."

"We're watching his every move without letting him notice."

Betrayal upon betrayal. Everyone was scrambling to get what they wanted. Director Hong had simply chosen comfort and survival for the years he had left.

"And the security team?"

"All thirty members are on constant standby."

The security team was handpicked from Ares Guild's elite. Every member was an A-rank Hunter. Their abilities went without saying, and their loyalty was just as impressive.

The master they served had changed suddenly, but these were men who would handle a murder without batting an eye.

And I'm no different.

Go Se-won had done all kinds of dirty work under Lee Jungryong.

Sometimes he was disgusted by what he'd become, but until now, he'd managed to live with it.

That work had made him wealthier than most people could dream of being. It had also let him meet his beautiful, loving wife after he turned forty and finally get married.

But…

Have I been doing this too long?

Maybe this was the hypocrisy of a man who had forgotten what it meant to go hungry. Maybe it was the disgust he'd spent years suppressing.

Or maybe it was his son, who had only just started walking, and his wife, who had recently become pregnant with their second child.

Song Cheonwoo's youngest grandson is about Sangho's age, isn't he?

The thought of ordering his men to abduct a child too young to speak left him uneasy.

No. We'll be lucky if it ends with kidnapping.

Go Jun had become a different man in the past month or two. No one knew what he might do next, now that he'd grown so violently ruthless.

Even Lee Jungryong, who had never been particular about his methods, had left children alone…

"Team Leader Go."

Go Se-won straightened at his superior's voice.

"Yes, Vice Guild Master."

"Prepare the security team. You know what I mean, don't you?"

The gentleness in Go Jun's voice made Go Se-won's hair stand on end. After a brief silence, he answered.

"Yes."

"I'd like results as soon as possible. Is that too much to ask?"

Go Se-won already knew his answer.

He was just another piece of shit in the same shit pit. He'd stepped into the mud long ago. It was too late to turn back.

"No, sir. I'll bring you good news by tomorrow at the latest."

"Good. You may go."

That was the end of the conversation.

Go Se-won walked out of the office on stiff legs and raised a hand to his ear.

Beep.

The communicator he'd switched off for a while gave a faint chirp and lit up.

"Report the current personnel."

As soon as the brief command ended, a sharp voice came through the communicator.

“Team One, all members standing by. Nothing to report.”

“Team Two, all members standing by. Nothing to report.”

“Team Three, all members standing by. Nothing to report.”

The three teams had thirty members in total. Even within Ares Guild, where only the best were gathered, they had been chosen from among the best of the best.

Go Se-won possessed overwhelming skill befitting the Head of Security, but even he could not easily guarantee victory if five or more of these men joined forces. No matter how thoroughly the target had prepared, there was no way to stop them.

“Orders from the Vice Guild Master. Finish your preparations and assemble in one hour. Our final destination is…”

Go Se-won paused, then said in a low voice,

“London, United Kingdom.”

They wouldn’t need passports for this trip.

Advanced illusion magic and special makeup concealed their faces, names, and even fingerprints. Exactly one hour later, they gathered before a long-distance Teleportation magic circle.

Then they walked into the dazzling light.

Whoosh!

The next morning, Go Jun received the news he’d been waiting for from his Head of Security.

“It was a success. Of the security team’s thirty members, two were killed, but the rest—”

“What about Song Cheonwoo’s family?”

“…We captured them all alive. Teams One and Two have stayed behind, disguised as the existing security personnel. They’ve taken control of the mansion and are keeping watch.”

“Well done. I knew I could count on you, Team Leader Go.”

“The team paid a heavy price. We made the most of our advantage and took them by surprise, but security at the mansion was tighter than expected. Two of our men were killed…”

“It’s fine. You took care of the aftermath, right?”

After a short silence, Go Se-won answered.

“Yes. We’ve taken control of their communications network, and we used enchantment magic to learn every code word and reporting procedure. Even if someone contacts them, they’re unlikely to suspect much.”

“How long can you keep it up?”

“Four days at most.”

"That's long enough to finish this. Contact that old man, Song Cheonwoo. Tell him Lunar New Year is coming and it's been too long since we saw each other."

Go Jun laughed aloud, imagining the look on the old traitor's face when they met. Then he looked up.

"Oh, and Team Leader Go."

Go Se-won had been watching his superior with an unreadable expression. He quickly composed himself.

"Yes, Vice Guild Master."

"Sorry. The good news made me forget."

"Oh."

"You know how distracted I've been lately. You understand, don't you?"

"Not at all, sir!"

His answer came out more forcefully than before.

Of course. No matter how much he's changed, he wouldn't do that.

Go Se-won waited for the words he'd been hoping to hear. Instead, Go Jun's next remark stopped him cold.

"You're always working hard. Take this for yourself."

"…!"

Slide.

Go Jun set a spotless white envelope on the table.

Considering the nature of the matter, it obviously contained a check for a substantial sum. Judging from his experience, it was probably at least ten billion won.[2620]

But an envelope of bonus money wasn't what he'd wanted.

Still…

"Thank you, Vice Guild Master."

Go Se-won accepted the envelope politely and bowed deeply.

By then, his gaze had grown deep and unreadable as he stared at the man reflected in the spotless, gleaming marble.

Martial arts are made up of countless movements.

Thrusting and cutting. Striking and smashing.

Link movements like those together, and they become a form.

Whoosh! Bang!

I punched into empty space. Compressed air exploded, and my hair fluttered.

I continued through the forms against an imaginary opponent.

[2620] Ten billion won is about $7.1 million or €6.5 million.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! Slash!

Everything I'd seen and learned firsthand, every insight I'd gained, flowed into the forms. One led naturally into the next without pause.

Forms linked together. A combat sequence.

Boom-boom-boom!

The edge of my hand. My elbow. My shoulder. Every part of my body turned and twisted as I struck in every direction.

Learning martial arts had taught me once again that a weapon didn't have to be a blade.

Anything that can hurt an enemy is a weapon.

That was why training mattered. With enough of it, you could break a neck with one finger or split a rock with a rusty carving knife.

Whoom! Bang!

My heel came down like lightning and slammed into the ground. That strike would have crushed the skull of even an A-rank monster with a hard outer shell.

But there were no enemies to bring down here.

The hundred or so corpses—human or monster—existed only in my imagination.

"Hoo…"

I let out a quiet breath.

Clap, clap, clap.

A vigorous round of applause rang out from behind me.

Chapter 568

Clap, clap, clap.

A vigorous round of applause rang out. At the same time, the voice of someone I'd been aware of for a while echoed through the room.

"Impressive. Very impressive."

Click.

Shiny black dress shoes came toward me. The man wearing them had on suit pants with razor-sharp creases and a leather coat that reached his knees. He stopped in front of me.

"Mr. Jin, I've heard a great deal about you… but coming all the way here was worth it. You're even more impressive than I expected."

I had no idea what was going on, and it must have shown. He answered with an easy smile.

"There's no need to be so flustered. The time has simply come."

"The time has come?"

"Yes. Did you think you were the only hero in this world?"

"What?"

"From this moment on, you've become part of a much greater world. You simply don't know it yet."

"…!"

A sharp current ran through my entire body. I let out a low groan and glared at the unwelcome guest.

"What the hell are you?"

"Not many people know my true identity."

He gave a quiet laugh and continued.

"As for who I am…"

"No, I'm asking what the hell you're doing."

"Huh?"

His eyes went round, as if this wasn't how the scene was supposed to go. I stared at him for a moment, then waved a hand.

"Never mind. Keep going. You've still got lines left, right?"

"Can I?"

"Sure. Finish them."

He cleared his throat and gave me a solemn look.

"My name is King Fury. Director of Barrier…"[2621]

Wham!

[2621] This parodies Nick Fury, director of S.H.I.E.L.D. in Marvel superhero films.

"Urgh."

I punched him in the face. The Skeleton King staggered like a drunk, and I followed up with a string of punches.

Wham! Wham! Crack!

"Urgh! Ugh! Wait! Wait! My jawbone!"

"Like hell I'm waiting, you fucker."

This guy needed a beating.

While some people were working their asses off day and night to build a bright future even in times like these, he had suddenly popped up dressed like a movie character.

I'd wondered why he was wearing a leather coat all of a sudden.

"Having fun? Are superhero movies *that* much fun?"

The Skeleton King, who'd been getting pummeled nonstop, suddenly set his face and raised a thumb.

"Fucking awesome."

"…"

"I hate them three thousand."[2622]

"What the hell is wrong with you?"

"Wait! You've cracked a bone!"

Wham! Wham!

"How can you call yourself human? Huh?"

"I—I'm a monster!"

"This bastard only claims he's a monster when it suits him. Is your species a buffet? You just pick whichever one you want?"

Wham! Wham!

"Wait! Stop for real this time! I've got an orbital fracture!"

"…"

That was a surprisingly precise diagnosis for a monster.

The medical terminology made my fist hesitate. The Skeleton King promptly slipped away, trembling with humiliation.

"You vile human. You aren't even a person."

"My God. Did a monster just say that to me?"

"You devil. When Judgment Day comes, may you be cast into hell."

"Have you been going to church lately? That's a strange choice of words for you."

The Skeleton King froze for an instant, then cleared his throat.

"A human woman…"

"What?"

[2622] "I love you three thousand" is a line from the superhero film *Avengers: Endgame*.

“A beautiful human woman spoke to me first. I met her at the crosswalk up ahead. She said if I followed her, we could all sing songs and eat good food.”

“…And?”

“So I went. It wasn’t particularly fun, but it wasn’t bad. A man called a pastor must have recognized my nobility, because he even presented me with a gift.”

“My God.”

An undead monster had gone to church. Was this for real?

While I was still at a loss for words, the Skeleton King lowered the collar of his coat, which he’d turned up like a middle-aged man from forty years ago.

“Heh heh. Behold.”

I’d doubted my ears before. Now I doubted my eyes.

Peeking proudly out from between the coat collars was none other than a cheap cross necklace.

“This is the symbol of a noble king.”

“…”

Wasn’t it a symbol of exorcism?

For a moment, I wondered whether he’d met an exorcist rather than a pastor. But Magic Johnson’s illusion magic was flawless. There wasn’t the slightest hint that anything about the Skeleton King was out of place.

His social media followers, whose numbers had grown exponentially, were proof of that.

Click.

“…You’re taking a selfie right now? Want me to smash your phone?”

“I bought it with my own money. A vile human has no right to say anything, so keep your mouth shut.”

A monster who’d adapted to capitalism. Maybe that was the real monster.

And since he’d bought it himself, I couldn’t argue. It wasn’t even some undisclosed sponsorship. He’d paid for it with the money he’d recently received from the Peace Guild.

“I’m quite a high earner among humans now. I hear the people of this world sort themselves into classes by annual income. Mine is a full six hundred million won![2623] Heh heh. And I’ll be making that much for the next ten years!”

“…”

Welcome to ten years of slavery.

If the Skeleton King were a Hunter, he’d qualify for S-rank with room to spare. Yet Team Leader Choi had him working for a mid-level Hunter’s salary.

Team Leader Choi’s cruelty made me want to give Hyuk Mujin’s balls a sharp tap.

[2623] Six hundred million won is about $430,000 or €390,000.

"What's that look for?"

"Nothing. Don't worry about it. Keep earning lots of money."

The Skeleton King narrowed his eyes and looked me up and down.

"Suspicious. And not just now. You've been acting strangely these past few days."

"Who? The undead monster who went to church?"

"You, vile human!"

He shouted, then went on.

"You keep getting lost in thought even inside Gates. A man without so much as a finger joint's worth of culture starts drawing pictures and taking notes. Yesterday, you even turned down an emergency rescue call, so I had to go in person!"

For a monster, he was pretty perceptive. Maybe because I'd spent more time with him than anyone else lately.

I scratched my chin and looked at him.

"I get what you're trying to say. So?"

"Huh?"

"What do you want from me? I'm not allowed to think? I can't draw a few pictures and take notes?"

"I—I didn't say that."

He faltered, then rallied.

"Even so, that emergency rescue call—"

"I put it off because I could. They still had you."

"Wha—what?"

"It wasn't a Mutated Gate, and from how much the magical power reading had risen, I figured it would be fine. So I sent you instead."

"You sent *me* in your place?"

He blinked at me, mouth hanging open.

"Why?"

"Because I trust you to handle it."

"…!"

"I'd been going with you just in case. But I've seen what you can do, and after hearing what other people had to say, I figured you could go alone."

The Skeleton King was a Named Monster in every sense of the word.

He had possessed powerful abilities even back when he was called a Warlord, but after his battle with the Arch Lich, he had evolved into an even more powerful being.

An ordinary Named Monster wouldn't stand a chance against him.

From what I'd seen firsthand, his physical abilities were exceptional. He could also use his own Authority to raise a one-man army.

In that respect, none of the S-rank Hunters alive today could match him. Though a Grand Mage like Magic Johnson, who could dominate an entire battlefield, might be another story.

And there's me, too.

The Skeleton King was an undead Lü Bu[2624] who could sweep a Gate by himself. There was only one reason I'd kept someone that powerful at my side.

His complete and utter lack of social skills.

He'd never come right out and announced what he was, but he went around advertising that he was born to be a monster.

If I had taken him to the official Blue House[2625] press conference last time, he would have referred to President Baek Hanseong as a "human male." Then the Liberation Army,[2626] led by the Lady of the House,[2627] would surely have risen up, waving Korean flags and demanding that they investigate the identity of that long-nosed bastard.

But now…

"This hyung[2628] can finally relax. You even went to church, you little punk. Go on, live a little more freely from now on."

Pat, pat.

I patted his shoulder. The Skeleton King's eyes widened—perhaps at the warmth of my touch, or perhaps at one word I'd said.

"F-freely?"

"Yeah. You've reached the point where I can trust you with things. You deserve that much freedom."

"Vile human. Weren't you keeping watch on me?"

"Keeping watch?"

I gave a quiet laugh.

"After you saved my life in China?"

"That…"

"Sure, you owe me too. Neither of us needs to say it out loud. Just know I've always been grateful."

"…!"

His golden eyelids quivered. He looked at me with an expression I couldn't quite place, then opened his mouth, eyes wet.

"Vile human."

"Oh, shit. Don't say anything."

[2624] Lü Bu was a Chinese military commander famed for his prowess in battle.

[2625] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea's president.

[2626] The Korean Liberation Army was a force organized to fight Japanese colonial rule.

[2627] "Lady of the House" refers to a wife or woman who presides over a household.

[2628] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male he is close to.

“But I have to say this.”

“Don’t. Seriously. I hate this kind of mood.”

I could almost hear soft background music playing somewhere. I looked off toward the distant mountains, uncomfortable, as his voice reached me.

“Then can I go to a club tonight?”

“…”

“That mage tricked me into going to a gay bar twice. This time, I intend to enjoy some noble bump-and-grind at a club.”

“…”

Noble bump-and-grind, my ass.

Give me back my emotions, you bastard.

“Please, vile human. I swear I’ll be back before midnight!”

“Fine. Go.”

“R-really?”

“Yeah. Go. If you want to die.”

“…”

“You crazy bastard. A club? What kind of trouble would you get into there?”

Hearing that he had gone to a gay bar twice did make me feel a little sorry for him, but the Skeleton King still wasn’t socially developed enough for that.

This had nothing to do with the fact that I’d never been to one myself.

…Really.

“Why? How can this happen when I’m so handsome!”

As the Skeleton King howled in anguish, the smartphone in his hand vibrated.

Bzzzz.

His face crumpled when he checked the screen. I didn’t need to look to know why. It might as well have been projected as a hologram.

“Emergency call?”

“…Damn it.”

Talk about timing. I checked the call details, then looked up at him.

“What are you waiting for?”

“I refuse, vile human. You go this time.”

“What are you talking about? One look tells me all I need to know. You can handle this by yourself.”

“Damn it! Why do you get to play around here while I work?”

Play around? Who?

But he had no way of knowing what I was doing.

I gave a quiet laugh and raised a hand instead of answering. He caught the hint and darted out the door.

Bang!

The door slammed shut and did not open again from sunset until the following morning.

And then…

Inhale. Exhale.

Whoosh. Boom!

In that quiet, isolated room, I circulated my qi and trained without pause.

It was a long journey in search of a path I'd never taken, with the faintest thread of a clue in my grasp.

A pale face. Trembling fingertips.

When had it started? A drop of cold sweat that had run down the back of his neck while he listened fell with a soft *plop*.

"W-what did you just say?"

He had the imposing build of a man whose age of seventy seemed impossible, along with the face of a middle-aged man. But the voice that slipped between his lips was as faint as that of someone standing on the brink of death.

What he'd just heard was that shocking.

"Th-that is…"

Even remembering what he had heard made his vision swim. The old man barely pulled himself together and forced out his trembling voice.

"You—you kidnapped our children?"

"'Kidnapped' sounds rather unpleasant. Someone might get the wrong idea."

"Y-you dare…"

"So let's call it protection."

Across a table laden with an elaborate feast, Go Jun answered brightly and took a bite of steak.

Juice from the rare beef ran down his angular jaw. His next words, added almost in passing, cut into the old man's ears.

"For now, at least."

"…!"

Go Jun smiled with pleasure at the frozen face of the old man, Song Cheonwoo.

Chapter 569

Thud.

The door closed behind Song Cheonwoo with a sound like thunder. His sturdy frame—hard to believe he was seventy—staggered.

Slide. Tap.

Neither his powerful mana nor the experience he had gained through a lifetime of hardship was any use to him now.

He braced himself against the wall and stared at the floor. A pair of black dress shoes stepped into view.

“Are you all right?”

At the sound of the businesslike voice, Song looked up, saw who the shoes belonged to, and gritted his teeth.

“Does this look all right to you?”

Head of Security Go Se-won bowed beneath his furious glare.

“I’m sorry if that sounded insensitive.”

“Spare me the words you don’t mean. Before I break your neck!”

“I wouldn’t recommend it. You’d have nothing to gain and plenty to lose.”

Go Se-won gave a gentle wave of his hand. At the far end of the hallway, the security-team members who had started toward them stopped.

“They’re my men. As you know, Director, they’re quite capable. And when the situation calls for it, they don’t care what they have to do.”

“You…”

“Please don’t misunderstand me. I only mean that I don’t want you to make matters worse.”

Crack.

The marble beneath Song’s hand, reinforced by magic, split in a spiderweb of cracks. He glared at Go Se-won through bloodshot eyes and forced the words through his teeth.

“So you kidnapped my children? They had nothing to do with this. They’d done nothing wrong.”

“They were exceptionally well guarded for people who supposedly had nothing to do with it. That means you had at least considered the possibility, Director.”

Two security-team members had died despite the whole team taking part in the attack. Given that they were among the best Ares Guild had to offer, it was *no fewer than* two.

“I regret what happened to your family. But if you suspected this might happen, you should have sent even more people to protect them.”

“…!”

"I shouldn't have said that. I apologize."

Go Se-won meant it. Song Cheonwoo was already like an old lion whose death had been decided. There was no need for Go Se-won to drive the knife in himself.

Would he believe me if I said it slipped out because I felt sorry for him?

Go Se-won was a father too. His first son had been born after he turned forty, and his second child was due in a few months. Both were already more precious to him than anything.

He would give his life for his children's safety and happiness. That was what it meant to be a father. A parent.

But Song Cheonwoo had weighed his ambition against his family's safety. Then again, if he had imagined the worst, he would never have tried to make an enemy of Go Jun.

...Not that I'm one to talk.

Go Se-won felt like a pathetic villain.

For well over a decade, he had lived more like a fixer than a Hunter. Ever since Lee Jungryong had noticed him and brought him into the security team, his main targets had been people, not monsters.

He was the one who had ordered his men to kidnap Song Cheonwoo's family and then cleaned up the aftermath.

And I have the nerve to lecture him.

They were all pieces of shit in the same shit pit.

Song Cheonwoo had let ambition consume him on the verge of retirement and brought danger upon himself. Go Jun swung his blade without caring what it took to get his way. And Go Se-won had become the sword in his superior's hand and kidnapped Song's family.

A war between bastards. In the end, there'll be a winner and a loser.

And he was nothing more than a component.

He was swallowing the bitter thought when—

Grab!

A hand far too strong to belong to a seventy-year-old man seized his collar.

"Team Leader!"

"Enough. Stay at your posts."

Go Se-won stopped his men and calmly looked up at Song Cheonwoo, who stood a full head taller than him.

"I told you. You stand to lose more than you'd gain."

"You bastards dare lay a hand on my children...!"

"The Vice Guild Master is listening inside. I don't know what the two of you discussed, but I hope there won't be any more unnecessary sacrifices."

"...!"

Go Jun held his family's lives in his hands. Go Se-won was telling him not to make Go Jun angry.

Song understood at once. His eyelids trembled, and though he kept glaring at Go Se-won through clenched teeth, his grip slowly loosened.

"You made the right choice."

"…Shut your mouth. I'd like nothing more than to smash your face in right now."

"I'm sure you would."

A bitter smile touched Go Se-won's lips. He would have felt the same in Song's place.

And even twenty years after leaving active service, Song Cheonwoo was still an extraordinary fighter. His ability simply hadn't matched his ambition. The fact that he had once been Lee Jungryong's political rival said enough about him.

Which is why Go Jun chose a method this dirty.

Go Se-won disliked it. But dirty as it was, it would work.

Song Cheonwoo would be eliminated soon, and it would look so natural that no one would suspect a thing.

"Follow me. I'll escort you outside."

Go Se-won bowed slightly and started down the hallway. Song cast one last glare at the closed door, then followed.

Step. Step.

Go Se-won had sent his men away. Only their footsteps sounded in the hallway until Song broke the silence.

"What you said earlier. Was it true?"

"…?"

"You said you didn't know what Go Jun and I had discussed. Was that true?"

Go Se-won considered the question for a moment, then nodded.

"I see. From what I found out about you, I suppose you were never much of a strategist."

"What do you mean?"

"It seems he doesn't trust you as much as I thought. Or perhaps he wanted to hide it even from his closest aide."

Song gave a weak, hollow laugh at Go Se-won's frown.

"Go Se-won."

In the brief span of time between one breath and the next, he seemed to have aged ten years. No—twenty. He continued in a desolate voice.

"There's such a thing as a line a person shouldn't cross. You know that?"

"…If you're criticizing the Vice Guild Master, I'd ask you to stop."

"Criticizing him? That's a much gentler word than I'd expected. Far too gentle for that bastard Go Jun."

“I understand how you feel. But no one involved in this has the right to condemn anyone else. I know you haven’t lived a particularly clean life either, Director.”

“Heh. True. There was a time when I’d use any means necessary to get what I wanted. But I never went this far.”

Song laughed again, empty and almost unhinged. Go Se-won fell silent.

Song wasn’t talking only about the kidnapping.

What is it?

His heart pounded. A current ran down his spine.

This was a warning. A danger signal telling him not to listen.

But his body moved contrary to his thoughts.

“What limit are you talking about, Director?”

“A monster who has forgotten even the most basic duty of being human.”

“What?”

Step.

Song stopped before the Teleportation magic circle leading outside. He stared at it for a moment before speaking again.

“The boundary between human and monster. That bastard Go Jun… has already become a monster.”

The old man’s empty gaze drifted through the air. As though searching through memories of a brilliant past, he took a weary step toward the magic circle and left Go Se-won with one last plea.

“I apologize for what I did to you. So please, don’t let those children die for nothing.”

Flash!

Before Go Se-won could ask what he meant, Teleportation magic manifested, and dazzling radiance swallowed Song Cheonwoo’s body.

Go Se-won stood alone, staring in confusion at the spot where Song had been. Then he turned.

The hallway was made entirely of white marble. At the far end of its long stretch stood a closed door. Behind it, someone was probably sipping wine, pleased with himself.

What in the world… have you done?

Go Se-won muttered toward something deep inside his heart.

Section A, which was always filled with light, felt like a pit overflowing with darkness today.

I had no idea how long I’d been shut away in the training ground—or training room, as they called it in the modern world.

One day. Two. Maybe three.

The walls blocked out everything beyond them, and the temperature stayed the same. Once I got absorbed in martial arts, I lost track of time.

Even though I had a smartphone, I never looked at it, so I had no way of knowing. Perhaps they vaguely understood my situation, because no one from the Peace Guild came to see me or contacted me.

"…"

Saying it like that made me sound like a complete loner. Which I absolutely wasn't.

…Probably.

The Skeleton King hasn't come by once since then, either.

It was good news in one sense: he seemed to be handling things better than I'd expected. But it also meant the emergency rescue team was busier, and more Gates were showing signs of abnormal activity. I couldn't exactly celebrate.

What I *could* celebrate was that my own attempt was nearly complete.

It's not finished yet, though.

I had never tried anything like this before, and the process so far had been anything but easy.

The pressure of having to create something exceptional while the current situation was on the verge of exploding may have contributed as well.

What I have now might be good enough…

Should I just take the plunge and go with it?

I'd asked myself that dozens, maybe hundreds of times. I was going over it again when the training room door opened with a familiar mechanical sound.

"So this is where you were. I need your help, as it happens."

Step. Step.

Combat boots polished to a shine. A skin-tight blue suit. A shield with a skull on it.

I gave him a look colder than the snow piled on the roof of King Sejong Station in Antarctica.

"Look at this fucking bastard."

"You heard from Director King Fury,[2629] didn't you?"

"…Are you playing two roles now?"

"Heh heh. Surely a citizen of the United States of America ought to be King-tin America.[2630]"

"This bastard keeps changing his name however he wants. I'm going to beat you so badly you'll want to go back to the glacier."

"I can do this all day."

[2629] King Fury is the Skeleton King's version of Nick Fury, the Marvel character who directs S.H.I.E.L.D.

[2630] King-tin America is the Skeleton King's version of Captain America. The blue suit, shield, and "I can do this all day" line continue the Marvel reference.

Whoosh! Boom!

White Flame shot toward him like a streak of light. Its spearhead grazed his neck and pierced the training room wall, burying the shaft.

The Skeleton King looked from the spear to me, then muttered, “All day might be difficult…”

“Cut the bullshit. Why are you here? If you dropped by because you were bored, I’ll kill you. Seriously.”

He answered in a hurry.

“N-no, that’s not it. It’s a mission. A mission!”

“A mission?”

“That is correct, wicked human.”

He nodded.

“It isn’t an ordinary Mutated Gate. The magical power reading is enormous.”

“…!”

Damn it.

Chapter 570

Eight in the morning.

The new year had arrived, but people's daily routines hadn't changed. Office workers in neat suits hurried to work with tired faces, and the roads were packed with cars.

Honk! Hooonk!

At the constant blare of horns, the middle-aged man driving a midsize van rolled up his half-open window and grumbled.

"Fuck. Even the Great Cataclysm couldn't get this goddamn road fixed. Are we supposed to drive on it or not?"

Swearing behind the wheel was practically inevitable. Especially in Busan.

He laid on the horn at a compact car trying to cut in without signaling.

Honk!

Then again, if its driver had any sense, he wouldn't have needed to honk.

The compact car flashed its high beams in broad daylight to celebrate its successful lane change and cruised away. The middle-aged man spotted the message plastered across its rear window and swore again.

> A child is on board.

"Goddamn it. Is the kid on fire? Is that why you're driving like that?"

Only then did he realize he'd cursed aloud. He glanced at the passenger seat and cleared his throat.

"Ahem. That slipped out."

The young man beside him answered calmly.

"It's all right. It happens."

He spoke to the driver, but his eyes remained on the view outside. The middle-aged man glanced at him.

"Your name was… Dongseok, right?"

"Yes."

"That's a relief. With things blowing up all over the place these days, it's hard enough to remember someone's full name."

"It happens. Don't worry about it."

"Ah, I don't know if I told you last time, but my name is…"

"I'll call you Team Leader. That's easier for me."

The Team Leader blinked, taken aback by the prompt answer. Lee Dongseok added, just as abruptly, "And, Team Leader."

"Uh, yeah?"

"The light's changed."

Hoooonk!

The horn behind them snapped the Team Leader back to his senses. He stepped on the gas, and as the van lurched forward, he frowned.

What a rude little shit.

But he soon reconsidered. So what if Dongseok was rude? They'd only be working together for a day. As long as he did his job, that was enough.

He's a hundred times better than a rookie who shakes in his boots or some loudmouth who can't back up his talk.

The Team Leader was a C-rank Hunter who had worked freelance for years. He knew a capable fighter with lousy manners was preferable to someone pleasant and polite who couldn't fight.

At least he won't shit the bed and disappear like that bastard a little while ago.

A team member had made a major mistake inside a Gate and then gone into hiding, leaving them in need of a temporary replacement. Lee Dongseok was the man they'd found.

His résumé gave them nothing to complain about, and from what the Team Leader could judge for himself, Dongseok was a skilled Hunter. Skilled enough that it seemed strange for him to be freelancing.

Well, I'm not complaining.

Finding people was hard enough these days. Even now, the DJs chatting quietly on the radio were discussing the main reason Hunters were in short supply.

"We have a comment from Shin Ayoung, a woman in her twenties who lives in Pocheon, Gyeonggi Province. 'A Mutated Gate appeared near my home three days ago. It happened only ten minutes away, and I've been so anxious I can't sleep.'"

"Oh, no… You live right near it? That's awful."

"I remember seeing that on the news. Apparently it was extremely dangerous. There could have been a lot of casualties."

"Thank goodness they stopped it just before it became a Monster Wave."

The Team Leader turned up the volume.

As a Hunter, there was no way he could have missed the Pocheon Mutated Gate incident three days earlier. Even Dongseok, who had been staring out the window, seemed to be listening.

"Fortunately, there were no deaths this time either."

"That's right. They stopped the Monster Wave, so there were no civilian casualties, and the Mutated Gate was dealt with quickly."

"That was Peace Guild's Emergency Rescue Team, wasn't it?"

"Yes. Hunter Jin Taekyung didn't go himself, but Peace Guild's Emergency Rescue Team did an impressive job."

"Rising magic power readings have become a serious problem here and overseas. Of all the countries in the world, ours has been recognized for responding the fastest and suffering the least damage."

"It really is remarkable. And it isn't just Hunter Jin Taekyung and Peace Guild's Emergency Rescue Team. All the Hunters fighting monsters under these circumstances deserve our…"

As the DJ went on, the Team Leader stole another glance at Dongseok.

"Come to think of it, you're pretty impressive yourself, Dongseok."

"What do you mean?"

"Going on raids at a time like this isn't easy."

As magic power readings rose, monsters grew stronger. Mutated Gates, which had once appeared only once or twice a year, now made the nine o'clock news headlines about every three days.

The Team Leader turned the wheel and continued. "I'm doing it for my family, but you're still in your twenties. You don't have a household to support. Is it youthful ambition or something?"

"No."

"Hm?"

"I'm doing what needs to be done. I have to do it."

His answer was firm, his eyes suddenly bright with resolve. The Team Leader blinked at this unfamiliar side of him.

"R-really?"

"Yes."

"Well. Good for you. That's some dedication to your job."

Dongseok's response had caught him off guard. So had the determination in his eyes. *Sense of duty* was about the only way to describe it.

What's with this guy?

A rude young man burning with a sense of justice? A kid dreaming of becoming a hero in troubled times? Whatever it was, he was an odd one.

The Team Leader eased onto the brakes. When he parked in the Gate management office lot and got out, the team members who recognized the van came over.

"Hey, Team Leader Kim. You made it."

"You're here, hyung[2631]."

"You're early, oppa[2632]. But who's that with you…?"

"This is Dongseok. You know—the temporary guy I told you about."

[2631] *Hyung* is a term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[2632] *Oppa* is a term a woman uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom she is close.

“Ah, is that right? I could tell at a glance. He looks just like someone from Seoul.”

“I think he is. Dongseok, these are the rest of the team…”

The Team Leader naturally turned his head, then blinked. Something about Dongseok didn’t look right.

“Dongseok. Are you feeling sick?”

“…”

“Hey. Dongseok?”

Dongseok stood staring silently at the Gate, his face rigid. He wiped the cold sweat from his forehead.

“No. I just got a little nervous all of a sudden.”

“Hmm. You’re all right, though?”

“Yes. There’s no problem.”

The Team Leader eyed him doubtfully, but they were already at the Gate. The manager responsible for *Siren’s Black River*, the C-rank Gate in Haeundae, was ambling over from a distance.

“Oh, Team Leader Kim. You’re here.”

“Yes. We’re a little late.”

“No trouble, right? Got everyone?”

The Team Leader glanced at Dongseok and nodded.

“Of course.”

“You sure? You know they’ve tightened the regulations. If something goes wrong, you and I both…”

“I know, I know. Have you ever seen me or my team cause trouble? You’re going to inspect everything anyway.”

“With things the way they are lately, I can’t help worrying. And yes, I was going to inspect you.”

The inspection was quick. The manager checked everything, finishing with Dongseok, then grinned.

“All right. Go on in.”

With permission granted, the team began moving, talking noisily among themselves. Everyone except Dongseok.

At the back of the group, he stared at the Gate with trembling eyes.

Thump. Thump.

His heart hammered. He’d suffered from cold hands and feet since his days at the orphanage, but now his palms were so clammy with cold sweat he might have developed hyperhidrosis.

Don’t get nervous. Not until the very end.

He had a mission. A mission he absolutely had to complete.

Dongseok took a deep breath. At the front of the group, the Team Leader suddenly looked back.

“Dongseok. You really are okay, right?”

“…Yes.”

“You don’t look good, and you took your time answering. Your mind isn’t somewhere else, is it?”

“No.”

The Team Leader would never know that Dongseok had been slow to answer because he still wasn’t used to the name, not because his mind was elsewhere.

And Lee Dongseok—or rather, the man behind that name—had not forgotten his purpose for a single moment.

“Don’t worry. I’ll definitely do it.”

“What?”

For a moment, the Team Leader looked baffled. Then he gave Dongseok a look that said *What an oddball* and turned away.

They stood at the entrance to the Gate.

“All right, before we go in—everyone together. Safety first, today too!”

“Safety first!”

The chant rang out, and the Team Leader stepped toward the entrance.

“Let’s go in!”

Whoosh!

The rippling magical power swallowed them one after another.

As the others hurried inside, Dongseok lifted his head and looked at the sky.

It was a January morning. The sky was blue, and the wind was still cold.

And… this might be the last sky he ever saw.

“I have a mission for you.”

A voice he had heard several days earlier seemed to reach him on the wind, along with his own answer.

“I’ll do it.”

“Your life could be at risk.”

“The former Vice Guild Master saved my life in the first place.”

He had been told that his mother, whose face he had never seen, gave birth to him in a subway restroom. Wrapped in toilet paper and thrown into a trash can, the newborn survived by sheer luck. He was sent to an orphanage secretly supported by Lee Jungryong, where he grew up healthy and strong.

“If I can help… I’ll do anything.”

To him, Lee Jungryong was a father, and Ares Guild was the home he’d shared with that father. He could do anything for him.

"Leave it to me."

At his resolute answer, the other person had smiled broadly. Then he had handed him something—an object now kept deep in his subspace pocket.

"You must succeed."

That was the last thing he'd said. After receiving his orders, Dongseok changed everything, including his face and name, and went down to Busan with that precious, dangerous object in his possession.

"I… will definitely do it."

His turn had come.

He fought down his fear, steadied himself with those murmured words, and stepped toward the rippling field of magical power.

Whoosh!

About an hour later, the people outside the Gate saw what happened.

Beep beep beep beep!

The magic power reading climbed at a frantic pace. Then a change began too quickly for anyone to stop.

Kiiiiing.

A rift tore open in the air, and a dense breath of death blanketed the sandy beach of Haeundae.

After arriving in Busan through three Teleportation magic circles, I knew at once.

No—I could feel it.

"Aaaaaah!"

"Aaargh!"

Kwaaaang!

The countless screams and tremendous din coming from far away. And…

Kuuung!

The immense magical power shaking the earth.

"…Fuck."

Chapter 571

Busan.

Before and after the Great Cataclysm, it had been one of the three most populous cities in the country.

A very long time ago, a handsome, clever elementary school student on a family trip to Busan spent his nights practically glued to the window.

“Taekyung, what are you looking at?”

“That leg! It’s sparkling! It’s pretty!”[2633]

“Whoa, you’re right. Is she a fit model?”

“…Not that kind of leg, Dad.”

“Oh.”

“That bridge over there! The long, sparkly one!”

“Aha. Gwangan Bridge?”

“Gwangan Bridge? What’s that?”

“It’s the name of that bridge. You saw it earlier, but it’s even prettier at night, isn’t it?”

“Yeah! I want to go! Take me to Gwangan Bridge right now!”

My father looked at his demanding young son as though he couldn’t have loved him more.

“Oh, my boy. Your dad’s exhausted from driving all day, and look at you thinking only of yourself. Who did you get that from?”

“Then can I ask Mom what a fit model is?”

“…You really are my son. Pack your bag.”

It was one of the moments I would never forget. Walking hand in hand with my dejected father to Gwangan Bridge left a vivid impression on my young mind.

The bridge was impossibly huge and glittering. Beside me was my father, who was always too busy for us to spend much time together.

I even got him to carry me on his shoulders by threatening him, despite his complaints about a bad disc in his neck. What more could I have wanted?

“Dad, let’s come back next week! And the week after that! And next month too! You have to carry me on your shoulders again!”

“Haha. What am I going to do? If we do what you want, I don’t think I’ll make it here next month.”

“Why?”

“Because at this rate, my neck will break the week after next. How many bowls of rice have you been eating a day lately, Taekyung?”

[2633] The Korean word *dari* can mean either “leg” or “bridge.”

"I haven't had much of an appetite, so only five!"

"…That's my good boy. No wonder the night sky looked yellow.[2634]"

It was a happy memory. We talked about all sorts of things that day, and when we got back to the hotel, I excitedly told my little sister Hayeon and Mom all about it.

Watching me, my father rubbed his neck, gave a quiet laugh, and made a promise.

"When Hayeon's a little older and you're in middle school, let's come back to see the ocean. All right?"

"Really?"

"Of course. Here—promise."

He never got to keep that promise.

As his two children grew, there were more and more expenses. When my mother fell ill from pushing herself too hard at her side job, my father grew busier still.

Then, on an ordinary day, an extraordinary accident took his life.

But I remembered his promise.

My father was no longer with us, yet even after more than twenty years, the Gwangan Bridge I'd seen as a child remained vividly etched in my mind.

And now—

Ruuuumble.

Gwangan Bridge was collapsing before my eyes.

"Ah."

A sigh escaped between my lips before I could stop it.

My mind screamed at me to get over there with everything I had, but my body wouldn't move. It was as if an invisible hand held me in place.

It's… already too late.

I wasn't the only one thinking it.

The Skeleton King, who had come with me, and the mage who had brought us here watched with exhausted eyes as the disaster unfolded several kilometers[2635] away.

"N-no!"

The cry of the mage whose name I did not know was hollow, and the scene spread out in the distance below us was overwhelming.

That's…

A wave.

A wave dozens of meters[2636] high had struck the place where my father's promise could never be kept, the bridge crossed by thousands—tens of thousands—of vehicles every day.

Whoooosh!

[2634] In Korean, saying the sky looks yellow is an idiom for being dizzy from exhaustion or shock.

[2635] Several kilometers is roughly a few miles.

[2636] Dozens of meters is roughly tens to hundreds of feet.

Carrying tremendous weight and force, the wave slammed into the middle of Gwangan Bridge, a suspension bridge thirty-five meters[2637] high and 7,420 meters[2638] long.

Spray burst in every direction, and screams were swallowed by blinding white foam. Hundreds of cars cruising along at the speed limit were flung away like toys.

Boom! Crash!

With a deafening roar, the suspension bridge's towers and anchors shattered.

Hundreds of cables snapped. No longer holding up the bridge, they became gigantic whips lashing out in every direction.

Whooooooosh—boom!

It happened in an instant.

People and cars that looked like ants were swept away by the cables and vanished.

Red blood flowed where they had stood, unable even to leave a final scream behind. Chain explosions, the screams of those who had survived by sheer luck, and the frantic blaring of car horns all reached my heightened senses.

Honk! Hoooooonk!

"Back up! Back the fuck up, you bastard!"

"Aaaaaaah!"

"Please! Please get my child out! There's a kid here…!"

I felt dazed, as though I were dreaming.

An advanced civilization built on magic and science was crumbling like a sandcastle.

Gwangan Bridge, which held my childhood memories, collapsed beneath the weight of destruction and death. Those who survived abandoned their cars and ran for their lives, crying desperately for someone to help them.

"Save me! Please save me!"

"Mommy!"

Their screams woke me from where I stood frozen like a statue.

"Ah."

I had to save them. I had to stop this disaster.

I'd been still for only a few dozen seconds, but hundreds had already died. If I hesitated any longer, thousands—tens of thousands—would die.

Smack!

I slapped both cheeks as hard as I could. The sharp pain brought me back to my senses.

I spat out the blood from my split mouth and grabbed the Skeleton King by the collar.

[2637] Thirty-five meters is about 115 ft.

[2638] 7,420 meters is about 4.6 mi.

Grab!

"W-what?"

"I'm going. Get a grip."

"W-wait. Where are you—"

Before he could finish, I took a running start and threw him out the window with all my strength.

No. I launched him.

Crash! Whoooosh!

The magically reinforced floor-to-ceiling glass shattered, and the Skeleton King shot out like a cannonball.

Hearing his scream disappear into the wind, I kicked off the ground with all my strength as well.

I did not forget to leave one instruction for the mage, who had already collapsed from exhaustion.

"Call for rescue using my name. Anywhere—right now!"

I didn't know whether he'd heard me properly in his exhausted state, or where he would send the request.

Nothing mattered more than what was happening in front of me.

Boom!

The force of my leap made the high-rise building where the Teleport Magic Formation had been installed tremble.

As I shot through the sky, an angry shout reached me.

"You lunatic!"

The Skeleton King. He had fashioned wings of bone with his own power and was flapping toward me at high speed.

Or he would have been, if I hadn't blocked his path.

"Go somewhere else."

"What?"

"It's too widespread. We split up and cover it."

A Monster Wave—and in Busan, of all places, with its dense population.

It might have been different in a desert or a sparsely populated military zone like the ones I'd seen in Magic Johnson's footage. Here, thousands of people were packed into a radius of just a few kilometers.[2639]

I had to keep the disaster from spreading, no matter what it took.

"I'll take the bridge first. You…"

"Damn it. Got it."

I didn't have time to say more, but the Skeleton King understood.

[2639] A few kilometers is roughly 1–3 mi.

He swallowed hard and looked far below.

His gaze swept over the road swallowed by screams and chaos and the people running for their lives. Then it suddenly began to tremble.

“Fuck. What are those?”

“What do you think?”

I answered shortly, pulled a spare spear from my Inventory, and aimed it at the ground.

Through my greatly enhanced eyesight, it looked as grotesque as any other monster. The scales covering its entire body and the fins extending down to its jaw were repulsive.

Merman.

An aquatic monster that lived in places like the sea.

It had the form of a male merperson, but it was neither beautiful nor kind like the ones in fairy tales.

The hundreds of Mermen surging out of the sea and descending on the people below made that clear enough.

“Ssssss!”

“Karruk!”

They charged with unintelligible cries, barnacle-covered tridents flashing in their hands.

Beyond those flashing points sat a little girl, collapsed on the ground and crying.

“Waaaaah! Mommy!”

“Minhee!”

The child’s cries. Her parents’ screams as they turned back.

And hundreds of monsters rushing toward their first prey.

Now.

I shifted my weight.

My body, angled through the wind, turned sharply downward. Internal energy flowed through my dantian and burst from my feet.

Bang!

I began a steep descent, using **Stepping on Empty Air** to kick off the air itself.

But no matter how quickly I hurried, the girl would inevitably die before I arrived if things continued like this.

Go.

With a short breath, I hurled the spear I’d aimed at the ground.

Whoooosh!

A single spear plunged down like a bolt of lightning from an unreachable height.

Cutting through the wind, erasing space, carrying the two characters for *certain death—*

It pierced its target.

Splurch! Crunch-crunch-crunch!

The Merman leading the charge toward the girl, along with a dozen or so monsters around it, turned into a handful of blood.

Hundreds of Mermen stopped at once and stared up at the sky, mouths hanging open.

As I met their gazes, half ferocity and half confusion, I muttered, “What are you looking at, you sons of bitches?”

Inventory Open. Summon.

Click.

The instant two spears appeared in my hands, my arms were already swinging toward the ground.

Boom! Crack!

Scales harder than steel shattered, and fins tore apart.

One Merman, lucky enough to lose only half its body, let out a mournful death cry.

“Krruk, krruruk!”

So noisy.

Inventory Open. Summon.

Whoosh! Boom!

It was around noon, with the sun high overhead. Fireworks erupted where none belonged.

Sticky blood trickled down the railing of the tilted Gwangan Bridge.

More. More. One more time.

Open. Summon. And summon. Summon again.

It happened in the blink of an eye. The System operated instantly, and my movements were faster than the wind and more powerful than lightning.

As soon as I thought of it, my hand shot out. In only a few seconds, I seized dozens of spears and hurled them at the ground.

Die.

Whoooosh—boom-boom-boom!

They split apart. They burst.

Those who tried to block the spears died along with their tridents. Those who tried to run died before they could take a step.

When the girl who had been crouched and crying just three meters[2640] away began to hiccup, there was nothing left around her.

[2640] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

"Hic. Sob."

She looked about nine years old. Sobbing hiccups escaped through the little hands clamped over her mouth.

What did she see when she looked at me with those enormous eyes?

A monster that had defeated monsters? Or an angel come down from the sky?

I didn't know. But one thing was certain.

Unlike me… you won't have any good memories of this place.

A bitter taste filled my mouth. I landed lightly and, instead of trying to comfort her, crooked a finger.

Shhh.

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space. Qi reached out gently and pushed the girl toward her parents, who were running to her with anguished cries.

But that family's ordeal wasn't over.

Ruuuumble.

The sea had turned black beneath the sun.

I stared at the *thing* hidden inside another wave rising dozens of meters[2641] high and lowered the spearhead of White Flame.

[2641] Dozens of meters is roughly tens to hundreds of feet.

Chapter 572

How did this happen?

The thing blinked slowly as the question formed in its mind.

It had lived its entire life driven by instinct. Now, with intelligence far beyond anything it had known before, everything was confusing.

But it soon understood what had happened.

—Hu. Man.

Yes. That human.

Humans were small, strangely shaped creatures. Accursed things that occasionally invaded the black sea where it lived and stirred it up.

For countless years, *the thing* had fought them, driven by instinct and rage. Today had been no different.

But…

—What. Was. That. Human?

Several dozen humans had invaded the black sea.

Their weapons and magic brought down even the Mermen with their magnificent fins and the Sirens whose beautiful songs lured humans to them. Blood spilled into the water.

Then, as *the thing* sensed defeat and fought desperately on, one human stepped forward.

“Let’s stop here.”

He looked ordinary. Smaller than a Merman, and nowhere near as beautiful as a Siren.

Yet *the thing* knew instinctively: of everyone there, this was the only human who could kill it on his own.

The other humans, however, were different.

“Mr. Dongseok, sorry, what did you just say?”

“What are you doing in the middle of a raid, you crazy bastard? Move it!”

“That’s going to be difficult. I have something I need to do.”

“Something you need to do? Mr. Dongseok, what does that mean?”

“I told you. I’m going to see it through.”

“Wait. Mr. Dongseok, I’m asking because I really don’t understand what’s going on here…”

Shing.

“M-Mr. Dongseok?”

“T-Team Leader Kim! That guy…!”

Whoosh—slash!

Confusion turned to uproar, uproar to a fight, and the fight to a battle. The battle brought death.

Crack-crack-crack!

“Ghk, krrk…!”

One against many. But the difference in strength was overwhelming.

In moments, the human had killed everyone who stood in his way. He came to a stop before *the thing*, which lay wounded where it had fallen.

Then he held out an object containing a power both irresistibly alluring and terrifyingly strong, and spoke words *the thing* could not understand.

“Absorb it. It’s a gift from that person to you.”

The thing had no choice. Exhausted by the long battle, it had neither the strength nor the energy to kill the human before it.

Its mind filled with the scent of what he held out.

Magic power.

That was exactly what it was: the primordial power *the thing* had possessed since birth, and a meal so tempting it could not resist.

Whooooooosh.

When the brief meal ended, *the thing* realized it had changed.

Its body had grown beyond comparison with what it had been, and immense magic power overflowed from within. The vast black sea it had known all its life looked strangely unfamiliar.

Almost as if…

“It’s cramped, isn’t it?”

The human’s voice came from far below. Without thinking, *the thing* nodded.

Yes. Cramped. The black sea that had once seemed so vast was now too small and shabby for it.

What should it do?

“Go outside. There’s a wider sea.”

The answer could not have been clearer. Reborn as something new, *the thing* looked down at the human who had solved its problem.

—Thank. You.

“…!”

And that was the end.

Crack! Crunch!

The human who had seemed so powerful was no match for what *the thing* had become. It wrapped him up, crushed his tiny body in an instant, and stirred the power lying within itself.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The black sea—everything *the thing* had ever known—began to shake.

Waves filled with magic power swallowed the human corpses and woke countless Mermen and Sirens sleeping in the deep sea. Amid savage roars and beautiful songs, magic power surged beyond its former limits. A dozen or so whirlpools rose around *the thing* and swept outward in every direction.

Whooooooosh!

A storm tore through the once-calm black sea and ripped open space itself.

Beyond the rift lay blinding light and a world *the thing* had never seen.

Whoosh!

Nothing could contain its magic power now.

Knowing its time had come, *the thing* became a single enormous wave and moved toward the new sea, carrying the countless Mermen and Sirens clinging to its body.

Crack! Whooooooosh!

The sunlight it felt for the first time was painfully hot. The endless blue sea was impossibly vast. And the sight of humans frozen in fear was enough to rouse the savagery it had briefly forgotten.

—Kill. Them.

A Monster Wave. The beginning of another disaster.

—Aah, aaaaaah!

Humans fleeing the Sirens' alluring songs turned back as if bewitched. The Mermen fell upon them.

Stab! Stab-stab-stab!

Screams and death swept across the sandy beach. Humans with special abilities came running, but they were no match for *the thing*.

Whoom—crack!

One Strike.

A single powerful sweep of its leg crushed a dozen or so humans to powder. What insignificant, feeble creatures humans were.

—To. A. Wider. Place.

The vast blue sea was *the thing's* now, and nothing stood in its way. It sent nearly a thousand of its followers ashore, one after another, then swam on beneath the surface.

Whooooooosh.

Easy. Everything was astonishingly easy.

Humans were weak, and it was strong. It would make those worthless things understand.

The thing roused the magic power coiled within its body. At the same time, it churned the water with limbs that had multiplied from eight to dozens.

Whooooooosh!

A wave dozens of meters[2642] high rose and hurtled forward.

Nothing could stop a wave carrying that much magic power. Everything human hands had built broke apart and sank.

The long, enormous structure built over the sea was no exception.

Ruuuumble!

The wave slammed into the suspension bridge called Gwangan Bridge. The wide-ranging defensive magic installed for emergencies shattered under its immense power, and the bridge broke precisely at its middle.

“Aaaaaah!”

“S-Save me…!”

Honk! Hooooonk!

The thing surveyed what it had made: the collapsing bridge, the terrified humans screaming, the noise pouring from objects it could not identify.

It was all satisfying.

At least until that happened.

Whoooosh! Boom!

In an instant, flashes of light rained down from the sky without pause, reducing some two hundred Mermen to pools of blood.

And then *the thing* noticed the presence of a human floating high above.

—Sky?

Could humans fly?

The question had barely formed when the human descended gently and landed.

Splash.

The human stepped into a pool of green blood and stared straight at it. Sunlight shattered against the spearhead he held at an angle.

—Guh…!

The thing groaned at the painfully bright glare. Then it made its decision.

—I. Will. Kill. You.

A savage red light flashed in the eyes on either side of its head. With a surge of immense magic power, dozens of legs struck the water.

Rumble! Whooooooosh!

Another enormous wave rose. The disaster it had summoned blotted out the sun, and *the thing* charged with a vast roar.

—Grrrrrrooooooar!

There, in the path of the terror of the sea—the Kraken—stood a human.

[2642] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–300 ft.

Of course the wave that struck Gwangan Bridge hadn't formed naturally.

Soon after the Great Cataclysm, many structures had been rebuilt to combine the best of magic and science. Gwangan Bridge, one of Busan's landmarks, was no exception.

But the fact that the powerful defensive magic on Gwangan Bridge was shattered by that wave…

The answer was clear. There was more than salt and seaweed in that water.

Something had torn through the boundary between worlds and emerged into ours.

I breathed out and tightened my grip on my spear.

"Come at me, you octopus bastard."

The Kraken took me up on it.

Whooooooosh!

Dozens of tentacles came at me with a tremendous shriek of displaced air. Their evenly spaced suction cups were so large they looked like black holes.

Damn it.

Who the hell said octopuses only had eight arms?

Internally clicking my tongue at the greater-than-expected number, I circulated internal energy through my legs.

Crack. Boom!

Spiderweb cracks raced across the hard ground, which burst apart beneath me. The recoil launched me between the Kraken's enormous tentacles.

An arc of White Flame slashed down like a flash of lightning.

Slash!

Three or four tentacles as thick as logs were cleanly severed.

They were only the relatively thin tips, but anyone would feel that pain.

The Kraken's tentacle, which had been about to strike the section of Gwangan Bridge where I had stood only moments earlier, twitched and trembled before slapping against the surface of the water.

Splash!

I had avoided the attack, but it was not over.

This is a bad place to fight.

Gwangan Bridge had already collapsed, almost split in two, but survivors were still scattered everywhere nearby. The screams coming from behind me were proof enough.

If I fought the Kraken here, there was a high chance of causing many unexpected casualties.

At this rate…

The battlefield, the surroundings, what I needed to do—there was only one answer.

Step. Tap.

The tip of my foot gently touched empty air.

Stepping on Empty Air. It consumed internal energy at a punishing rate, so I couldn't keep it up for long. I had no intention of dragging this fight out anyway.

Whooooooosh!

Nothing made an easier target than someone hanging in midair.

The Kraken's tentacles swept toward me as if dancing. I brought my spearhead down at an angle.

Fwoosh—shhhhhk!

Blue flames split into dozens of streaks and shot through the air.

However strong the Kraken was, it couldn't withstand Force.

Slash! Splash!

The tentacles swinging at me from every direction were severed in a single stroke.

Sizzle.

The Scorching Yang Qi carried by the Force burned the flesh even as it cut through. The Kraken roared in agony.

—Grrrrrrooooooar!

Of all kinds of pain, burns were the most agonizing.

I didn't miss the moment it faltered.

Bang!

Compressed air burst beneath my toes. The spearhead held upright plunged down, slicing through the fierce wind.

At its tip was the face of a gigantic octopus.

Shhhhhhhk!

Chapter 573

Everything had an order and a progression.

Mutated Gates were no exception.

When a magical power reading crossed a certain threshold, an alarm sounded and everyone nearby received an evacuation order.

But the ordinary Grade C Gate had become a Mutated Gate and then a Monster Wave in just a few dozen seconds.

The reading was so far beyond anything on record that the Gate management office could only suspect a measurement error.

Their deliberation lasted less than a minute. Then the Kraken tore through space into this world and smashed the Gate management office before anything else.

Boom!

And the flames of disaster spread in every direction in an instant.

The Kraken was the terror of the black sea, a king of immense power. And a king like that had savage, loyal soldiers.

—Ssssss!

Fins moved without pause. Gills opened and closed.

A Merman appeared, making a strange cry, and the intersection crowded with cars and people fell silent.

“What is that…?”

The question went unfinished.

Whoosh—crack!

It happened in an instant.

A barnacle-covered trident pierced through a human body and continued flying, punching straight through even a vehicle waiting at the light.

Boom!

Vehicle fragments flew in every direction with the sound of an explosion.

As people stared at the impossible sight, alarms around the intersection sounded and warnings arrived on their smartphones.

Weeeeeeeeng!

Ding. Beep-beep. Bzzzz.

The noise broke the silence.

People looked from the burning car to the Merman standing in the road. Only then did they realize the danger was right in front of them.

“M-Monster!”

“It’s a Monster Wave!”

“Aaaaaaaah!”

The crowds scattered, screaming.

All they could think about was getting away from the monsters and staying alive. Rules and laws meant nothing now.

“Fuck, move!”

“W-wait…!”

Crash! Crack!

“Graaagh!”

People knocked one another down. A car sped through a red light and struck a pedestrian in the crosswalk.

Hoooooonk! Thud!

“Ghk!”

After the Great Cataclysm, Korea had become the most densely populated country in the world.

An intersection in Busan, the country’s second-largest city, plunged into chaos and terror.

But there were exceptions.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Figures pushed against the current of the fleeing crowd.

There were only four of them, but their calm eyes and lightning-fast movements marked them as seasoned Hunters.

“Three o’clock!”

“Okay. All at once?”

“Cut down the ones in front first.”

“Don’t let them scatter!”

They had never met, but a few words were enough.

Each had spent anywhere from one to ten years fighting monsters. They knew exactly what they had to do.

If we don’t stop them here… we’re finished.

We have to hold them back somehow.

Fortunately, only around a dozen Mermen had appeared at the intersection.

None of the four was a particularly high-Grade Hunter, but against that many, they might be able to hold out and buy time.

“Surround them!”

They charged toward the Mermen. Then they stopped, despair taking hold.

Thud. Thud-thud. Thud-thud-thud!

—Ssssit!

—Ssssss!

The asphalt trembled beneath the weight of hundreds of Mermen charging toward them.

The first group had only been the vanguard. The main force had arrived.

And even this many might be just a fraction of it.

"…Ah."

We're finished.

All four thought the same thing.

Fighting a dozen Mermen would have meant risking their lives. For four low-to-mid-Grade Hunters, taking on this many was nearly impossible.

No—it *was* impossible without high-Grade Hunters to back them up.

"W-we could hold out until reinforcements arrive…"

"Hold out?"

A middle-aged Hunter muttered through clenched teeth in response to someone's almost desperate suggestion.

"We'd get hacked to death a thousand times faster."

"…Damn it."

His entire body felt as heavy as cotton soaked in water. He had to fight, but he could not bring himself to do it.

They had families. They wanted to live. Only their duty and resolve as Hunters kept them from backing away.

But they would not be able to hold themselves back much longer.

—Aah, aaaaaah!

When had she appeared?

A song spread from atop a tall building. Its singer was a pale beauty wearing a pearl crown, her long, flowing hair covering her naked body.

A Siren.

A witch whose beautiful voice bewitched listeners and led them to ruin. The queen of the black sea.

There was only one, but her haunting, powerful voice filled the wide intersection.

People who had been screaming as they fled looked up at the half-human, half-bird monster floating like an angel. They stopped, rapture on their faces.

The Hunters gritted their teeth against her magic, but it did no good.

Drip. Drip.

Blood slipped between their clenched teeth and ran down their chins.

The song burrowed into their ears. Their grips on their weapons weakened, and the hundreds of Mermen drawing closer blurred before their eyes.

"God… damn it."

They could see death coming. Neither they nor the nearly thousand civilians around them would escape it.

And the massacre wouldn't end here. Even if high-Grade Hunters arrived, they couldn't protect every one of Busan's millions of citizens.

Fuck. I didn't think I'd die like this.

It was too late. There was nothing he could do.

The middle-aged Hunter had given up. He was staring at the Siren through blurred eyes when—

—Aah, aaaaaah…!

Fwooooosh—crack!

Something shrieked through the air, and the song cut off.

Dark blue blood, the color of the sea, burst from the Siren. Her beating wings snapped, and the half-human, half-bird monster fell from the sky onto the asphalt.

Whoooosh—thud!

"Huh?"

—Ssssit?

With the enchanted song gone, their minds cleared.

The surviving humans and the Mermen who had watched their queen die stared at the fallen Siren.

Her eyes were frozen wide. The impact had knocked off her pearl crown and spread her hair apart, revealing something long and pointed jutting out between her breasts.

Was that…?

"Bone?"

The question had barely left the middle-aged Hunter's lips when—

Whooooooosh!

A strange noise rang out, and a shadow fell over everyone's heads.

Everyone looked up.

Something enormous and pure white covered the sky far above them. At its center stood a man.

"This body. Descends."

The arrogant yet powerful voice pierced everyone's ears.

When golden hair flashed briefly in their vision, the unidentified man pointed toward the hundreds of Mermen and continued speaking.

"You. Die."

—…!

The Mermen's eyes widened. At the same instant, the white mass casting its shadow over them flashed.

Papapapapat!

Bone. It was bone.

Sharper than spearheads and as fast as arrows, bone fragments rained down on the intersection.

Fwooooosh! Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Thousands of bone fragments fired at once smashed scales and tore through fins.

A Merman that barely managed to knock away several bone fragments with its spear was immediately turned into a pincushion by another fragment that came flying at it, then collapsed.

Thud-thud-thud!

The downpour of bones struck monsters alone.

Amid that horrifying spectacle, the humans stood frozen as they watched the neatly paved asphalt road become stained with monster blood in an instant.

Thump. Thump. Crash!

In little more than ten seconds, nearly half of the two hundred Mermen collapsed.

No. They had melted.

One Merman, apparently their commander, let out an urgent cry.

—Ssssit, ssssssit!

—Sss. Ssssit!

As half-human, half-fish creatures, Mermen were monsters of considerable intelligence. At their commander's order, they moved as one, raising the enormous scallop-shell shields strapped to their backs to form a wall.

The stranger—the Skeleton King—clicked his tongue.

"What insolent wretches. How dare you resist this body?"

It would make no difference. The Skeleton King's power was beyond anything mere Mermen could contend with.

"I shall make you pay dearly for defying a king… Hm?"

Rrrrk. Boom!

Sensing something amiss, the Skeleton King turned his head.

Far away, Mermen swarmed toward him like a colony of ants. His golden eyes took them in from behind his mask.

"…Would you look at these wretches."

There were more than five hundred at a glance.

As he took fresh offense at their insolence, the Skeleton King remembered something he had briefly forgotten.

Ah. Undead.

However urgent things were, he couldn't raise an undead army in the middle of a Busan intersection.

Especially not with nearly a thousand humans watching him, eyes wide open.

“Oh. This isn’t right.”

He muttered uneasily. Then anger surged through him as the face of the wicked human who had placed restrictions on him came to mind.

That damned human. He puts me through all this?

The thought that the bastard had deliberately sent him to the area with the most monsters made his breastbone feel twisted.

The Skeleton King whipped his head toward the distant sky, in the direction Jin Taekyung had gone moments earlier.

Whooooooosh!

Gwooooooar!

Boom! Krrrrr-boom!

Even from here, he could clearly see enormous tentacles and hear the explosions.

The Skeleton King silently watched the scene, then turned his gaze back toward the cluster of Mermen gathered below.

“…On second thought, they look like a girl group.”

It was the first time the hideous Mermen had ever looked pretty to him.

Whoooosh—boom!

Seawater surged upward with a sound like an exploding shell.

But the attacks were much weaker than before, and their reach had clearly diminished.

That was probably because the Kraken’s nearly thirty tentacles were down to nine.

Slash!

No. Eight now.

—Gwooooooar!

“Now that’s a proper octopus.”

I shot forward with all my strength toward the roaring Kraken.

I dodged an incoming tentacle and stepped on empty air, leaping higher. Beneath my feet was a gigantic pair of eyes.

Time to finish this.

Fwoosh.

Flames wrapped around the spearhead and spun faster. I poured all my internal energy into the spear and drove it down toward the creature’s eye.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, Third Form: Takoyaki.[2643]

[2643] Takoyaki is a Japanese snack of batter balls filled with octopus.

Chapter 574

Squelch!

The blade of White Flame pierced the enormous eye. The Kraken, terror of the sea, shuddered in agony.

But its pain was far from over.

Boom!

Flames burst forth, evaporating the blood. Powerful qi surged down the spearhead and tore through the Kraken's insides.

A full three jiazi[2644] of Scorching Yang Qi had done more than roast one of its eyes. It was enough to inflict grievous internal injuries.

—Gwooooooar!

Roaring in pain unlike anything it had ever felt, the Kraken whipped its eight tentacles in every direction.

It was trying to shake me off.

I held on, driving the spearhead deeper, and slammed my fist into its enormous eye.

Whoom! Thud!

With a divine weapon like White Flame in hand, I had little reason to use my fists or feet. But a fist thrown with strength and speed far beyond human limits was a deadly weapon in its own right.

Thud! Thud! Thuuud!

My fists came down like streaks of light, and the Kraken's massive body writhed again.

—Ghk, gwooooooar!

Boom! Splash!

Its eight tentacles hammered the sea, throwing up walls of water and raising waves.

I got drenched in salt water and licked my lips. The briny taste spread across my tongue.

"Stay still. I'm not done yet."

How many people had died or been injured in this Monster Wave?

The collapse of Gwangan Bridge alone had already caused hundreds of casualties. Every one of them was someone's father or mother, or a child so precious someone couldn't bear to see them hurt.

You have to pay.

The Kraken had destroyed more than a bridge.

[2644] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi equal 180 years.

Hundreds of precious lives had sunk beneath the white foam. So had promises made to people who would never be seen again.

Crack!

I tightened my grip on the spear shaft and sent internal energy surging through the mythical monster's body like an electric current.

Boom.

A small explosion sounded somewhere deep beneath its wet, glistening skin.

"Gaaaaaah! Hu. Maaaan!"

I had aimed for its head to end things quickly. But perhaps because of its enormous size, even a devastating blow couldn't kill it instantly.

I answered without the slightest hesitation.

"Give up. You're going to die here anyway."

That much wasn't going to change.

I felt the Kraken stiffen at my flat response. It must have been startled to hear a human speaking the Demon Realm language, which only highly intelligent monsters could use.

"You. Are. Clearly. Human."

"Of course I'm human, you fucking bastard. Do I look like an octopus to you?"

It was all thanks to the System's **Integrated Language Pack**, but I saw no reason to explain that to it.

Instead, while it hesitated, I drove a fist toward the area above its eye.

Fwoosh.

Blue flames flickered over my clenched fist.

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist—the technique that had once turned Tibet's Potala Palace into a "Crash Mansion."

The hammer of Scorching Yang Qi pierced the Kraken's skin, protected though it was by magical power.

Gwaaaaaang!

Keep striking even the hardest rock, and eventually it will break.

With enough internal energy behind it, the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist could bring down not just a rock, but a monster hundreds of times larger than a human.

Fwoosh!

Blue blood surged upward, and the Kraken's body trembled.

It had thrashed so violently that every yacht and fishing boat moored nearby was smashed to pieces. Now, instead of a thunderous roar, it let out a faint groan.

"…You. Human."

"Shut your mouth."

At last, I could see the end of this fight.

Sensing victory, I yanked White Flame from its eye at lightning speed and brought it down.

Or I was about to.

“Did you. Humans. Not give me. Power?”

“…!”

The spearhead stopped in midair, just short of piercing the Kraken’s head.

Countless thoughts flashed through my mind. I stared at it in confusion.

“What did you just say?”

Its limp body stirred at my question.

The Kraken was laughing. I was sure of it.

“Interesting.”

“Answer my question. Before it stops being interesting.”

“Did I not. Tell you? You were the ones. Who gave me power.”

“What do you mean by—”

Something felt wrong. As I tried to ask again, the Kraken drew a ragged breath and spoke.

“It must be cramped. Isn’t it?”

“…!”

“Go outside. There’s a wider sea.”

I froze.

That wasn’t the Kraken’s voice. It wasn’t the Demon Realm language, either.

Unlike its halting speech until now, this voice flowed smoothly. It was unmistakably—

Korean?

Yes. It was definitely Korean.

The Kraken was imitating someone I didn’t know. No—it was closer to replaying a memory exactly as it had happened.

The unfamiliar voice that followed confirmed it.

“The one who gave me power. The one who led me outside.”

Blue blood ran like a tear from its charred eye.

The Kraken looked at me with that eye—already dead, yet still full of hatred and despair—and continued.

“They were all human.”

“…!”

At the word *human*, a chill so cold it made me shudder climbed my spine.

Things that hadn’t quite made sense flashed through my mind, one after another.

The Monster Wave had moved so quickly that no one could respond.

The Kraken was extraordinarily powerful, even for a named monster.

And the Kraken itself had admitted that someone else was involved.

If all of that is true…

Someone deliberately caused the Monster Wave.

My teeth clenched at the thought. An artificially caused Monster Wave? It shouldn't have been possible. It should never be allowed to happen.

But…

Damn it. It is possible.

The total amount of magical power determined whether a Gate mutated or a Monster Wave occurred.

If the magical power exceeded the amount a Gate could contain, the two phenomena described above would occur.

And there was a way to raise that amount artificially.

Magic Gems.

The scattered pieces fell into place.

If it absorbed a Magic Gem containing a monster's magical power—an unpurified Magic Gem that had not undergone the purification process at human hands—it could be the only answer to this mystery.

But who? Why?

Someone had made the Kraken absorb a Magic Gem, turning it into a named monster. Then they had brought about a Monster Wave and unleashed this disaster.

It was terrorism. An atrocity no human should have been capable of committing.

Who would do that?

The hand holding White Flame trembled. Question after question crowded my mind, leaving it dark as a sky covered in clouds.

Ironically, only one creature could answer them.

"…Tell me. Everything you saw and heard."

I spat out the words. The Kraken gave a low, rumbling laugh.

"Why. Should I?"

"Because if you don't tell me right now, I'll kill you."

"How frightening. Truly frightening."

The mockery was obvious.

I pressed the spearhead farther in, but it only laughed through the pain and refused to yield.

"Ask. Your own kind."

"You fucking octopus."

"Kill. Me. Human."

"…!"

I clenched my teeth, fighting the urge to put a hole through the damned octopus's head right then and there.

Grind.

I had to kill it. I knew I did.

I had watched it all with my own eyes—the Kraken sacrificing hundreds of people.

If I included the other monsters under its command, the number of casualties might exceed several thousand.

Even now, someone somewhere in this city was probably screaming as they died.

But…

"…Fuck."

I couldn't kill the Kraken.

For what it had done, I wanted to beat it to death a hundred times over. A thousand times. But finding the person behind this damned disaster mattered more.

If I couldn't catch the bastard who had made the Kraken absorb a Magic Gem and brought about the Monster Wave, this would only be the beginning.

And people would die every time.

Was it the internal energy I'd spent? Or the unexpected existence of a traitor? My body felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton, and fatigue hit me all at once.

Sunlight beat down on my head.

Fuck. Of course the weather's nice.

It was a damn beautiful day and a god-awful situation.

I let out a rough breath and pulled White Flame from the Kraken's head.

Fsssh!

Blue blood gushed around the white spearhead as it came free.

I have to keep this thing alive.

The only witness—and the only one who could testify—was a monster.

Exhaustion weighed on me as I loosened my grip on the spear shaft.

Slide.

And that was both the only miscalculation I made in this battle and the most painful mistake.

Whoooooosh!

"…!"

It happened in an instant.

The Kraken's massive body, limp as though half-dead, thrashed. All eight tentacles came flying at me.

"Hup!"

Tap-tap. Whoosh!

I belatedly came to my senses, stepped on the Kraken's head, and launched myself into the air.

For a heartbeat, I thought I'd dodged the ambush.

Then I realized what the Kraken had really intended.

Fwooooooosh!

Black liquid spread through the air for dozens of meters[2645] in every direction.

It had planned this from beginning to end. With my guard down, I had no room to dodge all of it.

Splash!

Even moving as fast as I could, I couldn't avoid all of it as it spread across such a wide area.

And the instant the black liquid—perhaps roughly the amount in a cup of milk—touched my entire body, an unexpected System alert rang out.

Beep.

SYSTEM

You have come into contact with Kraken's Ink!
Kraken's Ink is a deadly poison with tremendous toxicity!
Status Abnormality: Poisoned has been applied!
Status Abnormality: Paralyzed has been applied!
Strength temporarily decreases significantly!
Agility temporarily decreases drastically!
Unaffected by a Hundred Poisons begins resisting!
Using internal energy can rapidly drive out the poison!

"…!"

My body grew heavy along with the System alert.

The black liquid was ink—and a deadly poison at that.

Damn it.

Why had I let my guard down? Why hadn't I suspected it right to the end?

The regret was bitter, but it was too late.

I drew up Scorching Yang Qi to counter the poison and put on the Myriad-Poison Ring from my Inventory.

Ding.

Another System alert sounded, and purification began.

But that was another mistake. The Kraken had seized the moment I let my guard down, and I wasn't its target.

Splashhhhh!

[2645] A meter is about 3.28 ft.

Its massive body shot forward like a ray of light, throwing up waves.

Gwangan Bridge lay ahead. Survivors were still there, waiting to be rescued.

“You…!”

“Human! Try. To. Kill. Me!”

There was scarcely time to think. Countless thoughts flashed through my mind, but the answer had been decided from the start.

A Murim warrior fought. A Hunter had to fight and protect people at the same time.

Crack.

I tightened my grip on the spear shaft, still cold despite all the blood it had soaked up.

In midair, I drew back my shoulder and twisted my waist. Internal energy raced through my coiled muscles and acupoints toward the spearhead.

Fwoosh.

Blue flames burned beneath the blazing sun. Sunlight shattered against the spearhead.

And then…

Now.

Die.

I swung my arm with every intention of killing it. The spear, engulfed in hellfire, shot forward as a beam of light.

Whooooooosh! Boom!

Compressed air burst outward, and the sea split apart.

At the end of its path was the Kraken’s enormous body, bearing down on the survivors.

Boom!

Blue blood fell like rain.

Chapter 575

I didn't need to see it up close or rush over to check for a pulse.

The moment the blue-flame-wreathed spearhead drove into the Kraken's body, I knew.

It's over.

Slash! Boom!

The spear cut through it, and fire qi exploded from within.

The monster's head, some ten meters[2646] tall, burst like a balloon. Blue blood that hadn't evaporated rained down over the sea.

And then—

Whoooooosh—

As the Kraken's enormous body finally collapsed, a clear chime rang in my ears.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 140 'King of the Black Sea' Kraken!
You have gained a large amount of EXP!
Myriad-Poison Ring has detoxified all poison within your body!
Status Abnormality: Poisoned disappears!
Status Abnormality: Paralyzed disappears!

Even with the System telling me I'd defeated the Kraken, my mouth felt as gritty as if I were chewing sand.

Damn it.

I should have kept it alive. Somehow, I should have kept it alive long enough to learn who was really behind this.

But one moment of carelessness had brought about consequences I couldn't undo. The Kraken was dead, and the question remained unanswered.

If it had attacked me directly, I might have had a chance to capture it, but…

Too late now.

The Kraken had been smarter than I'd thought.

It knew I was stronger than it, even poisoned. It knew it couldn't escape.

That was why it had gone after the survivors instead of me. It would rather die than be captured.

Faced with its final desperate move, I'd had only one choice.

[2646] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

"…Phew."

I sighed, looking at the Kraken's corpse half-submerged in the sea.

There had been no other choice. If I hadn't killed it with that one strike, someone would have died right in front of me.

People talked about sacrificing the small for the sake of the greater good, but that was just a pretty phrase. In the end, it was still a sacrifice—doing nothing while someone died pointlessly, despite having the power to prevent it.

I shouldn't have let my guard down. Not until it was over…

But what was done was done.

I was anxious and regretful that I had ultimately failed to uncover the truth behind the disaster. But I did not regret killing the Kraken.

People had survived because of my choice.

"Over here! Please, help us!"

"Cough! Please, my child…"

"Mom! Mooooom!"

Maybe fighting as far away from them as I could had helped.

Hundreds of people had been killed or injured before I'd even arrived, but there were still more survivors waiting to be rescued.

Their desperate cries came from the choppy water and the broken Gwangan Bridge. I forced down my exhaustion and shot toward them.

Fwooooooosh!

The briny, refreshing smell of the sea filled my nose.

I raced across the water like a gust of wind. Passing the Kraken's floating corpse, I reached the survivors and began pulling them up.

"It's dangerous out there, so everyone needs to stay here. If you still have the strength, help me rescue the others first."

A young man who looked relatively unharmed spat out seawater.

"Cough. B-but shouldn't we run somewhere else…?"

"Run?"

"Y-yes."

I raised a hand and pointed. Black smoke rose between the densely packed buildings all around us.

Ordinary civilians couldn't hear what I could, but my senses had already told me what was happening.

Hssssss!

"Tank! Three steps forward!"

"The building! The building is collapsing! The civilians are in danger!"

"Aaaaaagh!"

Rumble! Boom!

Faint screams and crashes. Humans and monsters were fighting in the streets not far away—and in several places at once.

“There are monsters in every direction. Still want to go?”

“…No. I’ll stay here.”

At least he caught on quickly.

The Kraken was dead, but this was far from over. If I was going to get this chaos under control, I had a busy day ahead of me.

Fwooooooosh! Boom!

The survivors stared, dazed, as I kicked off the water and shot into the sky.

Everyone ate. But who you ate with, and where, made a difference to how formal the meal was.

By that measure, the breakfast shared by the two people sitting across from each other had been formal indeed.

The late-starting breakfast had continued for a full two hours amid quiet conversation. By then, a beautifully decorated dish of sujeonggwa[2647] had been placed on the spotless white tablecloth.

“Since Seollal[2648] is just around the corner, I had tteokguk[2649] prepared… I’m not sure whether the meal suited your taste, Team Leader Choi.”

Choi Minwoo wiped his mouth with a napkin before answering the gentle, courteous voice.

“It was excellent, Mr. President. Thank you for taking such care.”

“Ha-ha. I’m glad.”

The middle-aged man across from him, President Baek Hanseong, smiled warmly.

“You’ve been so busy lately that I was worried you weren’t eating properly. So I repeatedly impressed upon the head chef here at the Blue House[2650] that you were an important guest and that he needed to take special care with your meal.”

“Important guest” was no empty compliment.

An invitation to breakfast at the Blue House[2651] already marked a person as powerful and influential. A meal alone with the President meant something more.

Baek Hanseong valued Choi Minwoo that highly.

“You eat well. It’s nice to see. Makes me proud, too.”

[2647] Sujeonggwa is a traditional Korean cinnamon punch, often served chilled with dried persimmons and pine nuts.

[2648] Seollal is the Korean Lunar New Year.

[2649] Tteokguk is Korean rice-cake soup traditionally eaten at Seollal.

[2650] The Blue House is Korea’s presidential office.

[2651] The Blue House is Korea’s presidential office.

Choi Minwoo dipped his head.

“Thank you. Still, I don’t go hungry as often as you seem to think, Mr. President. I feel I may have caused you unnecessary concern.”

“Oh? Well, I suppose you have a personal chef.”

“No. Someone has been making my meals for me lately.”

“Someone making your meals… Ah, do you mean…?”

Choi Minwoo gave a small nod.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung’s mother cooks for me.”

“My goodness. His mother does it herself?”

“Yes. I’ve tried to refuse—it doesn’t feel right—but she won’t hear of it.”

President Baek Hanseong let out a quiet exclamation.

He already knew Jin Taekyung’s family was staying temporarily at Choi Minwoo’s estate. Hearing Choi himself speak about it, though, gave that fact new significance.

If she’s even cooking for him… They’re closer than I thought.

Jin Taekyung and Choi Minwoo. Choi Minwoo and Jin Taekyung.

From President Baek Hanseong’s perspective, the two men were not only enormous fish he could never afford to let go, but also the only means of restraining the Ares Guild, which wielded tremendous influence.

Jin Taekyung, with his extraordinary standing. Choi Minwoo, Cheon Taemin’s maternal grandson and only living blood relative.

With those two on his side, Baek could rise still higher. After becoming the youngest president in Korea’s history, he might well become the first to win reelection under the amended law.

Whatever it takes, I have to bring them both over to my side.

While President Baek Hanseong entertained thoroughly political thoughts, Choi Minwoo was thinking about something completely different as he drank his coffee.

She said she was making dinner tonight… Kimchi stew, was it?

Strange. He had just finished breakfast, yet his stomach felt empty.

He wanted Jin Taekyung’s mother’s kimchi stew more than the tteokguk[2652] the Blue House[2653] head chef—a master of Korean cuisine—had prepared with such care.

Fluffy white rice from a pressure cooker of a kind rarely seen these days. Pork cooked until tender, and well-aged kimchi.

And the people huddled around the same table, frantically moving their spoons.

Hmm.

[2652] Tteokguk is Korean rice-cake soup traditionally eaten at Seollal.

[2653] The Blue House is Korea’s presidential office.

As Choi Minwoo realized he was unconsciously smacking his lips, he let out a faint, bemused laugh.

So that's what it is.

He wasn't particularly fond of tteokguk[2654] or kimchi stew. Nor was he looking forward to dinner because her cooking was better than the Blue House[2655] chef's.

He simply liked being there. The warm food, shared with warm people.

Home.

And family.

Choi Minwoo had lost both before he was as tall as the chair he sat in now. He had thought he could never have them again.

No. I do still have one family member.

A hero who had saved humanity. A living savior.

But a man who had been unable to protect his own family.

Choi Minwoo thought of the last time he had seen his maternal grandfather—a meeting he could no longer remember.

Soon… I'll see you again.

At the thought of the grandfather who had shut himself away for decades, a feeling he couldn't name rose within him.

Noticing that Choi Minwoo's mood had changed, President Baek Hanseong asked with concern, "Is something troubling you?"

"Ah. No. It's nothing."

"Ha-ha. I see. Well, now that we've finished eating, there's something important I'd like to discuss with you, Team Leader—"

The door flew open.

President Baek stopped mid-sentence. He frowned at the aide who had entered without knocking.

"I thought I told everyone not to come in."

"I'm sorry. I tried to avoid it, but you weren't answering…"

"Answering? Of course not. My phone's on silent."

With an important conversation under way, taking out a smartphone would have been discourteous, given who was at the table.

"Huff… I'm sorry. But it's urgent."

The aide was breathing hard, sweat beading on his forehead.

Sensing something was wrong, Choi Minwoo took the smartphone from inside his suit jacket. He had more than ten missed calls from Butler Kim and a string of text messages.

Dread rose in him.

[2654] Tteokguk is Korean rice-cake soup traditionally eaten at Seollal.

[2655] The Blue House is Korea's presidential office.

Don't tell me…

He opened the messages. One of his neatly groomed eyebrows twitched.

> **Butler Kim**
> └ **Butler Kim:** Butler Kim
> └ **Butler Kim:** Emergency Monster Wave in Busan
> └ **Butler Kim:** Extra-large named monster sighted
> └ **Butler Kim:** Young Master, where are you?
> └ **Butler Kim:** Young Ma□ter

The messages were from Butler Kim. They were short, but there was nothing small about the news.

A Monster Wave? In Busan?

Busan was Korea's second-largest city, home to millions. An extra-large named monster could cause an enormous loss of life just by doing a forward roll.

And what the aide said next made matters worse.

"The emergency alert was delayed for about ten minutes. The Monster Wave happened so suddenly, and the Gate management office and all the surrounding facilities were destroyed…"

"You idiot! Do you hear yourself?"

"I-I'm sorry."

Sweat poured down the aide's face as he continued.

"But according to the report that came in one minute ago, the extra-large named monster has been subdued. Hunter Jin Taekyung happened to arrive at the scene just in time…"

"What? Are you certain?"

"Yes. The remaining monsters are being dealt with, and survivors are being rescued."

"…Phew. At least that's a relief."

President Baek Hanseong exhaled in relief, while Choi Minwoo rose from his seat without hesitation.

The worst of the immediate crisis might have passed, but this was no time to sit and talk.

"I'll be going, Mr. President."

"Of course. We'll speak another time."

They exchanged brief farewells. Choi Minwoo had just left the Blue House[2656] when—

[2656]The Blue House is Korea's presidential office.

Bzzzzzt.

The smartphone he had turned back on began vibrating forcefully again.

Team Leader Choi thought he knew who was calling and answered at once.

“Yes, Butler Kim. I’m on my way ri—”

“It’s me.”

“…!”

Choi Minwoo stopped dead.

Song Cheonwoo’s aged voice came through the phone.

“Let’s talk for a moment. It’s urgent.”

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Click.

The short call ended. The signal ringing from the smartphone stopped, but the hand Choi Minwoo had raised to his ear did not come down easily.

He crossed the Green Garden in front of the Blue House[2657] residence, his expression conflicted. His steps had slowed. One thought filled his mind.

Song Cheonwoo wants to meet me. Right now.

Song Cheonwoo—the Trojan horse who could get him inside the impregnable fortress that was the Ares Guild.

Choi had been waiting for him to make contact. He simply had not expected it today, much less an immediate meeting.

He went over their brief conversation again.

What should I do?

Choi stopped dead.

Two paths lay before him, like the choice he now faced.

Busan. And Song Cheonwoo.

There was no time. He had to choose. He stared at the two paths, then finally started walking.

Crunch.

Frozen grass crumbled beneath the heels of his dress shoes. The path might have split in two, but both ways led to the exit.

A familiar face was waiting outside the main gate, beside the Blue House security office.

“Young Master.”

Choi greeted Butler Kim with a nod and stepped through the gate.

A sleek limousine, five black SUVs, and around twenty Hunters waited by the roadside. Every one of them was skilled enough to count among the elite of the Peace Guild, which had grown considerably. The Equipment they wore showed they were ready for battle.

Butler Kim’s next words confirmed Choi’s suspicion.

“We were waiting to escort you.”

“I’m sorry. Given where I was, I failed to check in time. More importantly, I heard that Mr. Jin Taekyung defeated a named monster. What is the current situation?”

“As you said, the named monster that appeared during this wave, the Kraken, has been eliminated. However, over a thousand Mermen have spread throughout Haeundae and Gwangalli.”

[2657] The Blue House, or *Cheong Wa Dae*, is the traditional name of South Korea’s presidential office and residence in Seoul.

“The damage must be severe,” Choi said quietly.

Busan might not have been as large as Seoul, but it was Korea’s second-largest city, with a population approaching five million. For a thousand monsters to appear there, especially monsters strengthened by the recent rise in magic power, was nothing short of a disaster.

But Butler Kim calmly shook his head.

“It isn’t something to celebrate, but fortunately, casualties are far lower than we expected.”

“Even if Mr. Jin Taekyung defeated the Kraken, he couldn’t have stopped all thousand Mermen.”

“Skel—no. The Stone King was there.”

“Ah.”

The face of the blond foreigner who always wore an arrogant, self-assured expression flashed before Choi Minwoo’s eyes. He gave a small exclamation and nodded.

With him there, it’s possible.

Only a handful of people knew the truth about the undead monster caught in an identity crisis between monster and American. Choi also knew he was every bit as powerful as an S-rank Hunter.

“Yes. Fortunately, thanks to the efforts of those two, the damage is not particularly severe.”

It was extraordinary luck. Jin Taekyung and the Skeleton King were each a one-man army. And unlike the Skeleton King, whose abilities came with various restrictions, Jin Taekyung ranked among the strongest in Korea. No, in the entire world.

Except for one person…

“What about our Peace Guild?” Choi asked.

“About five minutes ago, we dispatched the emergency rescue team and three teams we had standing by to Busan. The Guilds and Hunters based there, along with outside reinforcements, are doing everything they can to keep the damage from spreading.”

Choi knew by heart how many Gates, Guilds, and Hunters there were across Korea. He blinked a few times as he calculated, then asked, “They’ll have the monsters contained within two hours at the latest. Correct?”

“Yes. Of course, rescuing the victims afterward will take considerable time as well…”

“Then we can’t call Mr. Jin Taekyung or the Stone King away under the circumstances.”

“Forgive me, Young Master, but call them away for what?”

“Never mind. Let’s go.”

Choi's reply was quiet and final, but his lips moved again as he walked toward the limousine.

The words reached Butler Kim's ear through what could no longer properly be called message magic. It was Sound Transmission.

—He has requested a meeting.

"…!"

Butler Kim's eyes trembled. Choi had not named him, but there was no mistaking who *he* meant.

—Song Cheonwoo?

—Yes.

—Young Master, it may be dangerous. The Busan Monster Wave is already nearing its end. We could go back to the Guild House instead—

—He spoke about my maternal grandfather's safety. And about a trap Go Jun is setting.

Choi watched Butler Kim's face go rigid and continued quietly.

—I have to meet him. Right now.

The B-rank Gate in Pyeongchang, Gangwon Province, known as *Yeti's Winter Range*, was not an especially appealing raid site.

Even with exceptional physical abilities and Magic Equipment, fighting furry giants on a snowy mountain where your feet sank with every step was hardly pleasant.

Still, not everyone avoided *Yeti's Winter Range*. Some Hunters continued to visit despite the recent, repeated rises in magic power. The group that had just ridden the lift down was among them.

"Damn it. No entry, all of a sudden?"

"Right? Hey, Team Leader, are we getting paid for today?"

"…You're worse than a yeti. We couldn't even get into the Gate because the magic power went up, and you're asking about pay? Have you got no shame?"

"Aw, I got my hopes up for nothing. By the way, who were those people up there? The handsome guy wearing the mask looked kind of familiar."

"Beats me. How would I know—huh?"

The thirty-odd Hunters came down the path grumbling. Their Team Leader, walking at the front, suddenly widened his eyes.

A man was walking up toward them at an unhurried pace.

"Tsk, tsk. Looks like he's going to strike out too."

The man had obviously come for a raid. The Team Leader called out to him. He looked to be in his forties.

"Yeti raid?"

The middle-aged man paused at the abrupt question, then nodded without a word.

The Team Leader clicked his tongue. "Then you're out of luck too, Boss.[2658] Don't bother going up. They've closed it off."

"…"

"They say the magic power reading suddenly went up or something. Anyway, entry's prohibited. That's why we got turned back too."

"…"

"…Hello? Did you hear me?"

The Team Leader frowned when he sensed something strange. Without answering a single word, the middle-aged man who had merely listened to him walked past the group.

Step. Step.

"What's with that guy?" the Team Leader muttered as the man receded up the path.

To the middle-aged man, however, the Team Leader's goodwill was nothing more than needless meddling.

Clatter.

The man rode the lift up with a slight jolt and found dozens of pairs of eyes waiting for him.

A Hunter who looked quite capable stepped forward to bar his way.

"Sorry, but due to the rise in the magic power reading, you can't enter the Gate—"

"He's my guest."

At the quiet voice, the twenty-odd Hunters standing like a wall parted to let him through.

Two people stood at the end of the path they made.

"You're late."

At Choi Minwoo's flat voice, the middle-aged man whose appearance had been changed by an illusion spell—Song Cheonwoo—finally parted his tightly closed lips.

"I had to be careful. And you were the one who chose this place, Minwoo."

"I wasn't the one who suggested meeting at a Gate. Surely that gave me the right to choose which one."

"We had to avoid wiretapping and any other surveillance. None of it will work once we're inside."

"Then there should be no problem. This Gate belongs to the Peace Guild. It's a suitable place for both of us to be cautious."

[2658] *Sajangnim*, literally "business owner," can be used as a polite form of address for an unfamiliar adult.

"…Both of us? You suspect me?"

It was Butler Kim, standing quietly behind Choi, who answered.

"Why should the Young Master trust you?"

"Come now, Hwajong."

"Do not call me by my name. Whatever relationship we had ended long ago."

"…!"

Song Cheonwoo's eyelids trembled at Butler Kim's glacial stare.

Once, they had been close enough to call each other brothers. Then their paths had split between loyalty and ambition.

As an icy chill settled between them, a quiet voice rang out.

"I believe there's something more important we need to discuss first."

The words were gentle, but they cut to the point. Both men backed down. Choi glanced from one to the other, then turned toward the Gate entrance, where a field of magic power shimmered.

"You two will come inside with me. The other Guild members will keep anyone else from entering."

Choi went first. Butler Kim and Song Cheonwoo followed.

Whoooooosh.

Cold, sticky magic power enveloped them. When they opened their eyes again, a world of white stretched before them.

Yeti's Winter Range.

Snowdrifts lay in every direction across its steep slopes. Somewhere in the mountains, a monster roared.

—Kraaaaaaaar!

The three men remained unmoved by the bitter cold and the chilling cry. They were far too powerful to fear a mere yeti. Besides, they had come for a private conversation, not a raid.

"Tell me about my maternal grandfather's safety," Choi said. "And the trap Go Jun is preparing."

Song gave a bitter smile at the direct demand.

"Although I have not watched you for long… your personality has not changed."

"Just get to the point. I don't think I'm asking much."

Song let out a shallow breath. White mist rose into the wind as he spoke, his voice sounding older than before.

"Would you walk with me a little? I'd like to speak to you alone."

Butler Kim frowned. Choi answered evenly.

"Is that necessary?"

"You still suspect me."

“I still have no reason to trust you.”

“This Gate belongs to the Peace Guild, not to me or Ares. You chose it yourself. How could I have set a trap here?”

“…”

“I’m not stupid enough to try something against my only ally.”

Choi had been looking out across the snowy mountains. He turned and studied Song’s eyes. They did not waver in the slightest.

“Very well.”

“Young Master,” Butler Kim said.

“Don’t worry. I won’t go far.”

“…Then I’ll follow at a distance.”

Song nodded and slowly drew the weapon at his waist.

“I suppose I can’t stop you doing that. Suit yourself.”

“You—!”

“Don’t misunderstand.”

Thud.

What Butler Kim feared did not happen. Song drove his weapon deep into the snow for them to see, and Choi started walking.

Crunch. Crunch.

Snow crumbled beneath their feet as they walked side by side.

After a few steps, Song finally broke his silence.

“There’s a secret area inside Ares Guild headquarters. Only a handful of people can enter.”

“Are you referring to Area A?”

“…!”

Song’s eyes widened at the unexpected question.

“I knew the area existed and what it was called,” Choi said calmly. “I couldn’t find out anything more.”

“…Impressive. How did you learn even that?”

“I put in more effort than you might imagine. What I need now isn’t praise, though. I need details. What does Area A have to do with my maternal grandfather’s safety?”

“Because that person is there.”

Crunch.

Choi stopped dead at those two words. After a moment of silence, he began walking again.

“That information is not certain.”

“Why do you say that?”

“You were pushed out of the Ares Guild’s inner circle long ago, Director Song.”

“…That stings. But you’re right. I can’t be certain.”

“I also can’t see why my maternal grandfather would be there. No—I can’t understand it.”

“A reason…”

Song sighed softly.

“You wouldn’t understand. No one knows what happened to that person—not even you.”

“What are you—”

Choi Minwoo turned to him with a questioning expression. Then, at the next words, he froze.

“It happened more than twenty years ago. That person lost consciousness.”

“…!”

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Choi Minwoo's face had gone rigid. His eyes trembled faintly as he stared at Song Cheonwoo.

"What… do you mean?"

"You may find it hard to believe, but it's true."

Song continued with a sigh.

"It happened suddenly, one day. No one saw it coming."

"…!"

Choi clenched his fists without realizing it.

He did not trust Song Cheonwoo, but he could sense no trace of a lie in the old man before him.

Then is it really true?

His heart sank. A bead of cold sweat rolled down the back of his neck.

He barely managed to force the words past his tightly pressed lips.

"But I've never heard anything like that from anyone. Not even Butler Kim, who was my maternal grandfather's closest aide…"

Before Choi could finish, Song shook his head.

"It isn't that he chose not to tell you. He couldn't."

"Then…"

"I'm sorry."

Wouldn't and *couldn't*. A small difference in words, but an enormous difference in meaning. Choi understood what Song was saying and glared at him.

"You hid it from Butler Kim too? Something this important?"

The old man nodded quietly. When he spoke, his voice sounded older than ever.

"Hwajong was always loyal. And he gave that same loyalty to a child born after the war—a boy who lost his parents in an accident and was left alone."

"…!"

"Even on the day everything changed, your grandfather's most loyal aide was at your side."

Choi turned his head without realizing it.

Far across the snow, Butler Kim stood watching them.

If the howling blizzard had not swallowed Song's voice, that loyal servant would have come flying over to kill the traitor.

"Is that why you asked me to walk with you alone?"

"I had no choice. If he'd heard us, we couldn't have continued this conversation."

"If Butler Kim had heard about my maternal grandfather back then, you two would already have…"

His usual calm composure was gone.

Blue fire seemed to flicker in Choi's eyes. Song could not bring himself to meet his gaze and looked away.

"At first, we were only bewildered. We thought he would regain consciousness soon, so we kept it strictly confidential."

Crunch.

Song took a weary step and continued.

"But then a month passed. Half a year. A year. And a strange thought occurred to me. What if… he never woke up?"

Song Cheonwoo and Lee Jungryong.

What the two men had scarcely dared consider at first hardened into certainty as time passed. Then that certainty gave way to something else.

"Another year passed, and we recognized the greed in each other."

The greed to fill the place left vacant by Cheon Taemin, a man no one had dared challenge. The desire to become master of the great fortress that was Ares Guild.

"The purge began quietly one day. Unlike Kim Hwajong, who had already drifted away from Ares Guild, several of his closest aides knew of his condition. They died in Gates."

Choi bit down hard on his lip.

From ancient times to the present, death had been the surest way to bury the truth.

Lee Jungryong and Song Cheonwoo had chosen that path to usurp the throne of a king who was still alive.

Crack.

Choi's smooth lips split, and red blood ran down his chin. As he walked, his angry steps crushed the drops falling onto the white snow.

"You managed to survive, Regional Director. You really do have a stubborn hold on life."

Song answered his cutting words in a weak voice.

"Getting rid of me wouldn't have been easy for Lee Jungryong. Besides, we'd both covered ourselves in filth fighting over Ares Guild. He must have judged that I was unlikely to talk. He was right."

Knowing the truth was reason enough to be killed. Having wallowed in the mud together could be reason enough to be spared.

And to Choi, Song Cheonwoo had never seemed capable of fighting Lee Jungryong to the bitter end.

"Was the European regional director's position the price of that deal?"

"Yes. It saved my life and my family's."

Choi drew a deep breath. At last, the pieces of the puzzle that had eluded him fell into place.

Why Lee Jungryong, cold and thorough as he was, had kept Song Cheonwoo alive.

And why Choi's grandfather, his only blood relative and a symbol to the world, had not appeared in more than twenty years.

—Kraaaaaaar!

A yeti roared somewhere in the mountains, as if giving voice to Choi's feelings.

Damn it.

Crack.

The bones in his tightly clenched fist shifted audibly.

He wanted to scream. To ask why they had done it, and what they had hoped to gain. He wanted to shout at the top of his lungs, seize the old man walking ahead by the collar, draw the sword at his waist, and stab him in the back.

But…

Swish. Thud.

His hand moved toward the hilt, then fell away before it reached it.

Not yet. Song Cheonwoo would answer for what he had done, but only after Choi had confirmed all the facts.

Choi forced his pounding heart to settle and spoke in a trembling voice.

"Why did my grandfather collapse?"

Crunch.

Song's footsteps stopped. Ahead of him, the ground gave way to empty air.

A crevasse—the kind of fissure found in snowy mountains and glaciers—cut through the mountain. It was enormous, and its depths were too dark to fathom.

"Why. Why, you ask…"

Song Cheonwoo stared down at the darkness spread before his feet and muttered in a low voice.

"I don't know."

"Be clear. Do you not know, or do you want to pretend you don't?"

"Do you think Lee Jungryong or I pulled some kind of trick? On him, of all people?"

"That…"

Choi fell silent. He remembered who his grandfather was.

Cheon Taemin. Humanity's immortal hero. The first and last Hunter to defeat the countless monsters that had descended upon Earth, along with their lord, the Demon King Asmodeus.

The people he saved had given him the name Slayer. It was also a mark of the reverence Hunters held for a man whose strength none of them could approach.

"I respected him, and I feared him. Lee Jungryong felt the same. If we hadn't, we wouldn't have waited years for him to wake up."

It was true. Even after Cheon Taemin, the object of their respect and fear, collapsed, Song Cheonwoo and Lee Jungryong had been unable to act easily.

Before they revealed their greed, they needed two years, countless experiments to verify his condition, and a certainty still tinged with unease.

“Then what could have…?”

At Choi’s bewildered question, Song shook his head.

“No one can guess the reason. But one thing is certain. He is still alive.”

Song had answered the question Choi meant to ask next. Choi gathered his thoughts.

“What makes you so sure?”

“If he’d died, Lee Jungryong would have had no reason to keep me alive this long.”

“…!”

“But I do not know exactly where he is being kept. For now, I merely suspect Area A.”

“Area A…”

Choi murmured the name and raised his head. Song stood at the edge of the crevasse, gazing down into it.

“I have a few more questions.”

“Ask me anything.”

Choi studied his back in silence, then said, “I want to know why.”

“…Why?”

“Why are you telling me all this now? We’re working together, but before long, I’ll be your rival again. Why give me information this important?”

The enemy of my enemy is my ally. That was all Choi Minwoo and Song Cheonwoo were to each other.

They had joined forces temporarily to bring down Go Jun and claim Ares Guild. Nothing more, nothing less.

Which made Song’s behavior all the harder to understand.

He’s changed.

Their last secret meeting had been barely a week ago. Song had been cautious then, faintly wary in both word and deed. As a man who had once been Lee Jungryong’s political rival, he knew their alliance would end the moment it achieved its goal.

So why?

Information about Cheon Taemin’s whereabouts was a secret within a secret. Considering the confrontation that would come later, it was also a powerful weapon that could force Choi Minwoo to withdraw.

It was not something he could simply disclose on a passing impulse.

Choi's fingertips touched his sword hilt. Song, who had been staring silently into the depths, slowly turned around.

"The reason."

The old man's voice was calm now. The hesitation and faint tremor it had held when they met outside the Gate were gone.

Choi felt Song's gaze move to his hand.

"Call it atonement."

Choi tightened his grip on the sword. "Atonement for what?"

"I wanted to tell you someday, even if it was late. About the wrongs I committed against him—and against you."

"More than twenty years late."

"Yes. But I had no choice."

"That's an excuse."

Choi's answer was firm.

Then—

Rrrrrumble!

The snow-covered mountain trembled beneath its blanket of white. An avalanche was taking place beyond the crevasse, which stretched dozens of meters[2659] across.

Fur-covered giants rode atop the surging waves of snow.

—Kraaaaaaaaaar!

—Kauu!

Their savage roars shook the mountain. There were hundreds of yetis charging toward them.

"That's strange," Choi murmured.

"What is?"

"Yetis usually live in groups of around a dozen."

"Yes. They used to."

Crunch. Shing.

With the crevasse at his back, Song stepped forward. Choi drew the sword at his waist—a sword left behind by a hero who had fulfilled his duty even in death.

"That's a fine sword," Song Cheonwoo muttered, taking another step.

Behind Choi, someone was already hurtling toward them.

"Young Master!"

At the old servant's shout, Song muttered, "Understand. I had no choice."

And then—

BOOM!

[2659] One meter is about 3.28 ft; a crevasse dozens of meters across is at least roughly 80 ft wide.

A thunderous explosion erupted, and a blizzard came whirling.

Chapter 578

BOOOOM!

The ground heaved under a massive wave of energy called mana, and the snow thrown into the air rose like a colossal wall.

The moment everything turned white—

Rrip.

A dazzling streak of light tore through Song Cheonwoo's sleeve and shot outward.

The slender, razor-sharp blade was an unusual weapon, modified for this one strike.

I'm sorry.

With that brief apology, unheard by anyone, Song Cheonwoo moved like a flash.

Swish.

He lowered his stance, straightened his rear leg, bent his front leg at an angle, and put his strength behind the thrust.

The motion flowed as smoothly as water, perfected through more attempts than anyone could count. Wrapped in blinding aura, the blade pierced through space.

SHWAAA!

A sharp whistle tore through the air, as though it could cut anything in its path.

Song Cheonwoo had retired from active duty and was nearing seventy, but no one could deny his strength.

The instincts engraved in his body by the Great Cataclysm—and the tremendous mana coiled within him—defied the passing years.

There was no way a youngster who wasn't even thirty could block his strike.

It's over.

Song Cheonwoo was certain.

Until, an instant later, something stopped his blade as it pierced the wall of wind and snow.

SKRAAAK!

"…!"

A powerful resistance ran up the blade. Song Cheonwoo's eyes flew wide as a thunderous roar rang out.

BOOOOM!

Mana collided with mana. The gale from the impact clawed at everything around them.

The wall of snow collapsed, and snow scattered through the air.

Beyond it was a pair of deep, steady eyes.

"So this was the trap Go Jun prepared."

Song Cheonwoo let out a low groan. Choi Minwoo had caught the strike with the flat of his sword.

“How did you…?”

It was impossible. Song Cheonwoo clearly remembered Choi Minwoo’s stay at the European regional branch several years earlier, when he had still been in his early twenties.

The youngster had possessed outstanding natural talent, but his skills had fallen far short of it.

Yet now…

Rrrrrumble.

Song Cheonwoo could feel the strength behind Choi’s sword pressing against his own.

The young man facing him was no longer a youngster. He had become a formidable fighter.

And Song Cheonwoo’s plan had suffered a major setback.

So blood really does tell.

Cheon Taemin.

The name weighed on his heart, and suddenly his sword felt heavier too. But he had come too far to turn back.

He had crossed the river long ago and sunk his own boat. If he wanted to protect the family Go Jun held captive, he could not retreat.

I have to kill him here. No matter what.

Song Cheonwoo clenched his teeth. Mana surged through his sturdy body, seemingly untouched by age.

His wrist traced an arc, and the sharp tip of his sword slid across the flat of Choi Minwoo’s blade.

Clack. Swish!

It missed by a hair. The tip grazed past Choi Minwoo’s neck and stabbed into empty air.

Sword pressure split the skin of his neck, sending a stream of blood into the air.

Someone watching cried out.

“Young Master!”

The shout held grief, urgency, and fury.

The newcomer closed the hundreds of meters[2660] between them in an instant. With a flick of his sleeve, the surrounding air grew hot.

Fwoooosh!

[2660] Hundreds of meters is an unspecified distance of at least 200 m, or about 660 ft.

Flames made of mana erupted and rose between Song Cheonwoo and the others. The snow on the mountain melted and evaporated.

Through the scorching heat, Song Cheonwoo saw the old butler approaching beyond Choi's shoulder. Choi backed away, steadying his breath.

"So you've come."

Song Cheonwoo looked calmly at Butler Kim.

Once, they had called each other older and younger brother. Butler Kim had been one of the few comrades Song trusted to watch his back on the battlefield.

For both of them, that belonged to the past.

"I resented you, but I never hated you. But…"

Fwoosh.

A fierce heat burst forth. Flames formed in midair, coiled around Butler Kim's hands, and took on a new shape.

Song Cheonwoo gazed wistfully at the man now holding a whip of fire in each hand.

"Now you finally look like yourself. The Kim Hwajong I knew."

Butler Kim—no, Kim Hwajong—gripped the fiery whips and stepped forward.

Thud.

Lava seemed to boil in eyes that had always been calm.

The old butler, who had preserved his loyalty without wavering through all the years that had passed, had returned to the vigorous figure he had been in the past.

"Shut your fucking mouth, you piece of shit."

"…!"

Choi Minwoo stared, mouth open. He had never seen Kim Hwajong like this.

Swish! FWOOSH!

Following the arc of the sword as it swung, the wall of fire separating the three of them split apart.

And Choi Minwoo saw it.

Song Cheonwoo was watching them with a calm expression. Somehow, a pure white necklace now hung around his neck.

That's…

Song Cheonwoo spoke the name of the necklace Choi knew so well.

"It's a Yeti's Necklace. When you told me to come here, I thought it was bound to be useful."

Song Cheonwoo turned his head. Beyond the crevasse, hundreds of yetis were surging down the mountain with the avalanche.

"And this time, it seems I was right. Don't you agree?"

—Kyaaaaaaar!

Watching the hundreds of yetis charge toward them, Choi Minwoo felt his grip tighten around his sword.

A Yeti's Necklace.

Choi Minwoo knew what the little necklace did. So did Kim Hwajong.

Only a few months earlier, Won Myunghoon had prepared the magic item to trap Jin Taekyung in the Black Wyvern's nest.

A slave's mark that draws in dragonkin monsters.

Even monsters had their hierarchies.

Yetis, the giants of the snowy mountains, were slaves and prey to dragonkin. But the Yeti's Necklace did more than attract dragonkin monsters.

It marked its wearer as a slave of the dragonkin—and, to yetis, as one of their own.

"You…!"

Choi Minwoo's shout toward Song Cheonwoo never finished.

RUMBLE! Rat-a-tat!

An enormous avalanche swept forward. Hundreds of yetis raced across it as though riding a wave, then leaped over the crevasse.

Song Cheonwoo was closest, but while he wore a necklace carrying a yeti's scent, he was no different from one of their own.

—Kraaaaaar!

The savage roar shook the snowfield.

Song Cheonwoo glanced at the hundreds of shadows leaping over his head and charging toward the other two before speaking.

"Hwajong. You'd better stay out of this."

"You fucking bastard! I'll tear you apart!"

Kim Hwajong roared and swung his whips of fire.

Whoooosh! BOOM!

Flames of tremendous heat swept through the air, burning everything they touched. But the hundreds of yetis had been strengthened by magical power, and the deaths of their own kind did not slow them.

If anything, the magical power rising from them grew more ferocious.

—Kraaaaaar!

"…!"

There were too many.

Kim Hwajong bit down on his lip. Then Choi Minwoo's quiet voice reached him.

"It's all right, Butler Kim."

"Young Master!"

"The yetis will only make my fight harder."

"But…!"

“Go. I’ll take care of things here.”

Kim Hwajong stopped before he could argue.

For a moment, the old butler looked into Choi Minwoo’s unwavering eyes. Then, without a word, he kicked off the ground.

He swung the fiery whips in both hands, drawing the hundreds of yetis after him.

RUMBLE!

—Kyaaaa!

The yetis moved away in pursuit of the heat. At the same time, Song Cheonwoo stepped forward.

Crunch.

He took one step through the snow. His hand blurred, and his aura-wrapped sword tore through the air on every side.

SHWAAAAK! Slice!

Aura was the essence of mana’s true power.

The razor-sharp, destructive energy surged outward, cleaving through space. Wind, snow, rock—none of them could stop it.

Only another aura could.

Swish! Slice!

Sword strikes slashed through the air without pause. Skin split, and drops of blood flew.

Choi Minwoo narrowly avoided the streaks of light cutting across him. His eyes grew steady, and he tightened his grip on his sword.

Whoooosh.

Hero’s Soul. The sword left behind by a noble hero trembled.

Pure white aura, resembling the snowy mountain, coiled around the blade and surged upward. Choi Minwoo gripped the sword tightly with both hands and smoothly rotated his upper body.

Shiiiiing.

Aura against aura. Light against light.

The instant two flashes of different colors met—

RUMBLE-RUMBLE-RUMBLE!

A massive shock wave shook the mountain. Snowdrifts within dozens of meters[2661] turned to powder and scattered.

Two pale figures streaked through the white.

Swish, swish, swish!

BOOM! CRASH!

Two figures. Two swords. Their auras cut through the air and collided.

[2661] Dozens of meters is an unspecified distance of at least 20 m, or about 66 ft.

Each clash sent out another tremendous shock wave, sweeping away snow and tearing up the ground.

Red liquid dropped onto the dark green ground, revealed for the first time in ages beneath the snow.

Trickle.

Choi Minwoo felt hot blood run down his wrist. His shoulder throbbed, and cold sweat gathered on his forehead until it touched his eyebrows.

He had no time to stop the bleeding or wipe away the sweat.

The man facing him was still raining down sword strikes filled with killing intent.

SHIIING! Slice!

The attack missed by a hair. Solid rock split like tofu.

Choi Minwoo exhaled sharply as he dodged. His opponent's face came into view, his killing intent so fierce it made Choi's whole body prickle.

Song Cheonwoo.

A hero of the Great Cataclysm, once counted among the greatest Hunters alongside Lee Jungryong. His skill was terrifying.

It was one reason he had survived despite knowing a truth that could never be allowed into the open.

Shing!

Choi Minwoo jerked his head aside. Fierce wind sent strands of hair flying. A moment slower, and it would have been his neck.

So why didn't he feel the terror of death he had felt in Sichuan?

Heh.

A quiet laugh escaped him instead. He had suddenly remembered a conversation with someone who wasn't here.

"This might sound a little crazy, but sometimes I start laughing when I'm in a situation where I feel like I'm going to die."

"You really are quite insane."

"But… whenever I start laughing, I always end up winning somehow."

Choi Minwoo didn't know why that passing conversation had come to mind now.

But at last, he felt he understood a little of what the man had meant.

I won't die.

It was faith in himself. The will to keep fighting until the very end.

Choi Minwoo had made that insight his own when, exhausted and wounded, he had walked toward thousands of monsters.

Shing. Slice!

Burning pain shot through his thigh.

Choi Minwoo twisted, staggered, and Song Cheonwoo pressed his attack even harder.

Swish, swish, swish! Slice!

This time, it was his arm.

Thunk!

Then his side.

Choi Minwoo endured the pain and kept moving forward.

He met the rain of sword strikes, taking one step, then another. The sword in his hand trembled.

Whoooom.

Hero's Soul. The sword passed down to him from a hero who had fulfilled his duty even after becoming a vengeful spirit.

A legendary blade that granted greater power to one worthy of wielding it.

Fwooooooom!

The blade shuddered. Brilliant light swelled around its aura.

Song Cheonwoo's eyes widened.

"You…!"

"One last question."

Choi Minwoo's gaze was cold, but his voice burned.

He put all his strength into a single strike.

"Have you forgotten whose blood flows through my veins?"

"…!"

Shiiing!

A massive streak of light cleaved through space.

Within the blinding flash that filled his vision, Song Cheonwoo felt a bolt of lightning cut across his chest.

Slice!

Chapter 579

Slice!

The instant a streak of light cut across his chest, Song Cheonwoo felt his vision dim.

It's hot.

It was lightning.

The kind of lightning even a hero of old—one who had left his mark on the chaotic, perilous Great Cataclysm—had been unable to stop.

Song stared at the sword in his hand, his eyes trembling. Only seconds ago, it had shone with aura. Now something sharper and more destructive had cut it in half.

Clang.

The sword slipped from his grip and clattered across the ground. A beat later, pain swept through his body.

"Cough."

Drip, drip.

Dark red blood spilled from his mouth, staining the snow. His clothes and armor split diagonally, exposing his bronze-colored torso. A fine line across his skin and taut muscles glowed red.

SHWAAA!

An enormous amount of blood burst forth like a waterfall.

It ran from his left chest to his right hip. The injury left by that bolt of lightning was devastating. It would never heal.

Song staggered backward as the strength drained from his body.

Crunch.

His unsteady foot came down on blood-soaked snow.

One step. Two steps. Three steps. And then…

Fsssh.

At the sound of piled snow falling away, Song barely managed to steady himself. A massive crevasse gaped behind him.

He could retreat no farther. There was nowhere to go forward, either.

Damn it.

His chest felt hollow. Perhaps that was the life still draining out of him.

Song raised his head. Someone was walking slowly toward him.

Choi Minwoo.

The only blood descendant of *that person*, whom Song had always respected and feared. He remembered the quiet words he had heard just before the lightning struck.

“Have you forgotten whose blood flows through my veins?”

But now Song saw someone else in the young man before him. Someone who was not here, who existed only in his memories. Someone he could not have watched from nearby without feeling both reverence and fear.

Song realized something he had long forgotten: Cheon Taemin’s blood flowed through Choi Minwoo’s veins.

“…Hyung[2662]?”

The word escaped between ragged breaths.

Through Song’s blood-red vision, the young man holding a brilliantly shining sword looked like his maternal grandfather. His somber eyes seemed to ask why Song had changed sides.

“Don’t come closer. Stay away!”

Song shouted with what little strength he had left and swung his sword. Or thought he did.

The hand that had dropped it moments earlier was empty. It swept through the air until someone’s firm grip stopped it.

Whooom. Thud.

Choi Minwoo seized Song’s wrist and squeezed.

Crunch.

Bones shifted out of place, and Song screamed.

“GRAAAAAH!”

Thud.

Unable to bear the pain, Song fell to his knees. Choi gazed down at him, his eyes steady. What he saw now was not Song Cheonwoo, but an old man.

Zzt, zzt, zzt.

The radiance surrounding *Hero’s Soul* slowly faded. The fight had already been decided.

“Stop. It’s over,” Choi said quietly.

“…!”

Song went rigid. He had lost? Impossible. It could not happen. It should not happen.

But there was no denying it.

His trembling gaze lifted to Choi, whose calm expression made the bloody fight they had just fought seem unreal.

“How? How did you…?”

“I’m not sure.”

[2662] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

Choi felt the immense power flowing through his body. Only a few months ago, he had been unable to sense it. It was the only gift his maternal grandfather had left him—and Jin Taekyung had torn open the wrapping and returned it to its rightful owner, along with a way to put the gift to good use.

"Perhaps… because I was stronger than you."

That was not all. Choi had believed in himself and acted with an upright heart. In return, the sword imbued with a hero's soul had granted its worthy wielder even greater strength.

He looked down at Song, his gaze unwavering.

"I won, and you lost. That is all that remains between us."

"…!"

The old man's trembling gaze gradually settled. A hoarse voice came through his bloodstained lips.

"Yes. You're right. Though I didn't expect this outcome."

"Neither did I. I never thought we'd end up here."

Anger. Hostility. A faint trace of pity for a man who had fallen so far. Choi felt all of them, but above all, he wanted to know why.

Why had Song done this? And could Choi believe what Song had told him earlier?

"Why did you do it? If we'd worked together, driving Go Jun out and taking control of Ares Guild wouldn't have been difficult."

"I know," Song answered hollowly. "I thought so too."

"Then why?"

"I had no choice. It was an offer I couldn't refuse."

Choi already knew who had made that offer.

"Go Jun. Was it all on his orders? Our alliance, everything up to now?"

"Cough. Orders?"

Song spat out more blood and gave a feeble laugh. He was plainly laughing at Go Jun.

"If it were Lee Jungryong, perhaps. But that bastard is nothing more than a powerful, immature brat. I may be a despicable and pathetic old man, but I haven't fallen so low that I would submit to the orders of some young punk. My alliance with you was entirely my own decision."

"Then—"

"I told you. It was an offer I couldn't refuse."

Choi looked into Song's fading eyes and suddenly understood what the old man still had left—and what the offer must have involved.

"Your family."

Song gave a small nod.

“I didn’t realize until after I lost to Lee Jungryong. I’d forgotten what mattered most.”

His had been a hard-fought life. Before the Great Cataclysm, he had worked day and night to support his family. During it, he had been unable to leave the battlefield. Afterward, he had begun another struggle to reach the center of power.

Losing that political struggle to Lee Jungryong had reminded him how precious his family was. Then Lee’s death had rekindled his ambition, and Song had forgotten them again.

“My absence was the root of all this. I suppose this is the price an old man paid for reaching too greedily after ambition too late in life.”

“You’re probably right.”

Choi’s answer was cold. Hearing Song lament his own choices stripped away the last of his pity.

“Because of you and Lee Jungryong, I lost the only family I had.”

His voice was cold, but fury burned beneath it.

Because of two adults’ ambitions, a child too young to know what ambition meant had been left little better than an orphan. Before he could even understand that his parents were dead, his maternal grandfather had disappeared too. Choi had lived all these years resenting him.

“…I’m sorry. It was my fault.”

“Then I suppose you wouldn’t have any objections if I burned you to death right now. Would you?”

The voice came from somewhere above them. It was not Choi’s.

Crunch.

Kim Hwajong stepped onto the ground, covered from head to toe in blue yeti blood. Flames burned in the old butler’s eyes, matching the whip of fire in his hand.

“Hwajong. It’s you.”

“Shut your fucking mouth, you bastard. Do you know how much the Young Master __”

Kim looked ready to swing the whip, but a slight glance from Choi stopped him. The old butler pressed his lips together and stepped back.

Choi turned to Song.

“Then is everything you told me about my maternal grandfather a lie as well?”

“I wish it were a lie. But it is all true. I’ve already come too far.”

Kim frowned, unable to understand what Song meant. Choi let out a breath, torn between relief and disappointment.

His grandfather was alive. That was welcome news, even if he had been unconscious for more than twenty years.

But that could wait. For now, Choi had to decide what to do with Song.

—Young Master.

Kim's message spell carried pride in Choi, fury toward Song, and a faint hope. Choi shook his head. He knew what the old butler wanted to say.

—Butler Kim. That isn't possible.

—What do you mean, it isn't possible?

—Give me a potion. We need to treat him just enough to keep him alive.

—But…!

Kim looked ready to protest, but Choi's calm gaze made him hold back. He knew Song was a crucial witness—and, while alive, evidence in his own right.

He simply wished it weren't so.

"Butler Kim."

"Damn it. All right."

Kim cursed as he handed over a mid-grade potion. Choi's eyes widened.

"Did you just swear in front of me?"

"Yes, I did. Why?"

"I'd heard a little about this, but you're nothing like the man I remember."

"This is who I am. When you were little, I watched what I did and said in case you picked it up from me."

"Why stop now…?"

"You're almost thirty now. Since things have come to this, learn from me if you want to learn. Or don't."

Is this really the man who's been by my side since I was a child?

Choi let out a quiet laugh at the old butler's gruff tone.

"Butler Kim."

"What? And stop laughing. That's no way to treat an elder."

"Thank you. For becoming my only family."

"…!"

"I've always wanted to tell you that."

After saying it, Choi could not bring himself to meet the old butler's eyes. He turned away without another word.

At the end of the path before him, an old man lay buried in the snow, waiting for death.

Click.

Choi pulled the stopper from the potion. Its delicate, fresh scent drove back the smell of blood.

Song watched him approach through eyes that seemed about to close for good.

"Are you… going to save me?"

“Do you want to live?”

“I… That’s…”

Choi felt a surge of disgust at his hesitation.

“If I had my way, I would kill you a hundred times, a thousand times over.”

“B-but my family…”

“There must be a way to help them. We’ll deal with it once we’re out of here.”

“…”

“Choose.”

Song hesitated, then nodded with a look of resignation.

Choi gazed at him coldly and slowly tipped the potion.

Hiss.

The wound began to close the moment the milky liquid touched it. It was an extremely weak recovery, but to someone, it was a lifeline that could give them enough strength for one final effort.

Crack!

Where had that strength come from?

Amid the snow exploding in every direction, Song Cheonwoo launched himself with superhuman force and slipped into the enormous crevasse.

Chapter 580

News spread quickly: a Named Monster called the Kraken had landed in Busan at the head of thousands of Mermen.

Go Se-won was one of the few who heard about it before the breaking news appeared.

A Monster Wave…

He was human, too. Busan was a major city with a population approaching five million. He had never met any of those people, but the thought of countless civilians dying still left him uneasy.

At least Jin Taekyung is there.

Step. Step.

Guild members moving through headquarters hurriedly cleared a path when they saw Go Se-won.

He strode past them and muttered, “Security Team. Respond.”

Beep.

A faint tone sounded in his earpiece, followed at once by replies.

“Team Three. Transmission complete.”

“Team Two. Transmission complete.”

“Team One. Transmission complete.”

“I’m going to see a VIP. Open Area A and report your current locations and personnel.”

Go Se-won intended to ask his superior for permission to send the security teams to Busan.

It would help rescue people, and it would also help repair Ares Guild’s recently damaged image.

But as the team leaders reported in one after another, he frowned.

“All of Team Three are monitoring the target’s family in London.”

“All of Team Two have returned from London and are standing by in headquarters’ Area A.”

“Team One has nine members present. We’ve returned from London and are standing by on the hundredth floor of headquarters.”

“Team Leader of Team One. Say that again. What did you say?”

“Team One has nine members present. We’re standing by on the hundredth floor __”

“Forget the rest.”

Go Se-won stepped onto a magic circle as he spoke in a quiet voice.

Whoosh.

White light flared as the Teleport spell activated, taking him to Area A.

“Why nine instead of ten?”

“An urgent matter came up.”

“An urgent matter. Who’s missing?”

“Kim Ho-jung.”

“Kim Ho-jung?”

“Yes.”

Listening to the Team Leader’s dry voice, Go Se-won crossed the hallway in Area A. His mood soured with each sharp click of his dress shoes.

“That’s strange. I don’t recall receiving a report.”

“My apologies.”

“I’m asking for a reason, not an apology. Did he leave without permission?”

“Of course not.”

Of course he didn’t.

The security team was a pack of hunting dogs raised by the late Lee Jungryong.

For a long time, Lee Jungryong had secretly operated enormous orphanages and children’s homes, instilling loyalty in orphans who had nowhere else to go.

Go Se-won had been one of them. So had the others.

Team One, in particular, was made up of only the most loyal and capable. A member going AWOL was less likely than a Monster Wave.

Especially a member like Kim Ho-jung.

Which means…

Ares Guild had plenty of senior executives and elders, but the security team took orders from only two people.

Kim Ho-jung had vanished without reporting to Go Se-won, one of those two. That could mean only one thing.

Step.

His unimpeded stride came to an abrupt halt.

Go Se-won silently stared at a door with no nameplate or decoration when a bright voice rang out from beyond it.

“Come in. Don’t loiter out there.”

“…!”

Go Se-won swallowed and opened the door. His one direct superior was waiting in the neatly kept room.

“Nice weather today. Don’t you think, Team Leader Go?”

“Yes.”

Go Se-won bowed briefly, his gaze sweeping the room.

The pleasant smile at Go Jun's lips. The whiskey glass in his hand. And the object he was rolling around in his other hand.

What is that?

Go Jun was not acting like himself. Everything about the room felt unfamiliar and unsettling.

Perhaps it was the noise working its way into Go Se-won's ears.

Grind. Grate.

Go Jun's voice mingled with the irritating friction.

"You don't need to worry about Kim Ho-jung, Team Leader Go. I gave him a separate assignment."

"I see."

"Aren't you curious what it was?"

Their eyes met. Go Jun's looked unusually red today. Go Se-won lowered his head politely.

"No. If it was your order, Vice Guild Master, I'm sure you had a reason."

"That's good to hear. I thought you'd been feeling a little slighted lately. I am younger than you, after all, and you were always particularly devoted to Master."

"How could I? It's true that I owe the former Vice Guild Master a great deal, but that does not diminish my loyalty."

"Is that so? Then that's a relief."

Grind.

Go Jun rubbed the object in his hand again. Smiling, he swirled his glass.

"It's a nice day. Care to join me for a drink?"

Go Se-won answered evenly. "I'm sorry, but…"

"You mean you won't drink? What a shame. It's good liquor."

Go Jun leisurely emptied his glass. Go Se-won watched him in silence before suddenly speaking.

"There's an urgent matter I need to report."

"Go on."

"In Busan…"

Go Se-won trailed off. Beside the glass Go Jun had set down was a holographic PC.

The paused screen showed an enormous octopus and the shattered remains of Gwangan Bridge.

"What about Busan?"

"…"

After a moment, Go Se-won murmured, "You already know."

Go Jun gave a low laugh.

"I did. Before anyone else."

His voice was as cheerful as ever. Go Se-won's heart sank.

As the unease he had tried to dismiss revealed its true shape, he forced himself to speak calmly.

"Then is Kim Ho-jung… in Busan right now?"

"I seem to remember you saying you weren't curious a moment ago."

"I'm sorry. That slipped out."

"It's fine. You need to know anyway."

Go Jun answered pleasantly as he filled his empty glass with whiskey.

"That's right. Kim Ho-jung is in Busan on my orders."

He paused to think, then added, "Though he might not be there anymore."

"…!"

"Don't just stand there. Sit down and have a drink. My neck hurts from looking up at you."

This time Go Se-won could not refuse. No, he had no reason to. He needed a drink to steady himself.

Gulp, gulp.

He drained the strong whiskey in one go. Only then did he feel able to breathe.

Holding the empty crystal glass, he hesitated before forcing out the words.

"Vice Guild Master. I don't know how you managed to cause this, but it won't do much damage to them."

"Why do you think that?"

"Because he's—because Jin Taekyung is there. He even killed an Arch Lich. He's already bringing the Monster Wave under control. This will only add to the Peace Guild's Fame."

"Yes. Jin Taekyung. Quite a man."

Go Se-won had risked his superior's anger by mentioning the name. Instead, the smile stayed on Go Jun's face.

And that gentle smile made Go Se-won feel even more uneasy.

"Vice Guild Master. Don't tell me…"

"If you want to capture the commander, you have to lure out the general. There'll be an uproar if anyone finds out, but no consequences to worry about afterward."

"…!"

"We can't do anything about Jin Taekyung right now. Choi Minwoo is another matter. Don't you agree?"

Grind. Grate.

Along with the irritating sound of friction, one name flashed through Go Se-won's mind like a bolt of lightning.

"Song Cheonwoo. It's Song Cheonwoo."

"Correct. I'll give you another drink as your reward."

Go Se-won accepted it, hiding the tremor in his fingers. He could not begin to grasp how far things had gone wrong.

Even now, though, he was certain his superior's plan would fail.

"…Choi Minwoo is a cautious man. On the surface, he is the master of the Peace Guild, and he also has Kim Hwajong, who has served him loyally at his side for a long time."

"I know. Master told me about Kim Hwajong more than once. And with the other guards there, Song Cheonwoo can't manage it alone."

"Vice Guild Master. Then why in the world—"

GRRAAATE!

The loud sound of friction drowned out Go Se-won's voice.

Go Jun gave a quiet laugh instead of answering and opened his hand. At last, Go Se-won saw what he had been holding.

It was the size of an egg, and the darkness inside looked as though someone had gathered up the abyss and sealed it there.

"A Magic Gem…"

An ordinary Magic Gem would not have surprised him.

But the one in Go Jun's palm could only have come from a Named Monster. It was what people called an S-grade Magic Gem.

Pure, unrefined magical power swirled inside.

"V-Vice Guild Master."

Only now did Go Se-won understand how Go Jun had been able to cause the Monster Wave artificially.

At the dread in his voice, Go Jun murmured, "Choi Minwoo will die today. He will."

And Choi Minwoo's killer would be one of two: an old man whose family had been taken hostage, or another being whose identity even Go Jun could not clearly determine.

"One thing is certain. Song Cheonwoo has no choice."

Go Jun murmured the words quietly, then smiled with satisfaction.

He reached up out of habit to stroke the old necklace around his neck. Darkness flickered in his eyes.

If anyone had asked how Song Cheonwoo could still move in his condition, he would have answered in one word.

Will.

That was all it was: the last of his strength, drawn out by sheer force of will. The old man, now entering his seventies, threw himself toward death with everything he had left.

Flash! Whoosh!

The world slowed.

The cold touch of snow vanished. For an instant, his whole body felt weightless.

In that moment, split into fragments of a second, Song Cheonwoo met two pairs of eyes staring wide at him.

Choi Minwoo and Kim Hwajong. Their eyes seemed to ask the same thing.

Why?

Song answered them silently.

Because there's no other way.

A few days earlier, he might have taken Choi Minwoo's hand.

But the last time he had faced Go Jun, the man had become… a monster.

Song had seen madness in his eyes. If Song left this place alive, Go Jun would kill his family without a moment's hesitation.

Neither the Peace Guild, nor even Jin Taekyung or "that person," could resolve that problem.

So this is how it ends.

With that fleeting thought, Song fell toward the pitch-black darkness.

He could see no end to it. It looked like a monster's gaping maw—and like his own life.

Was it Nietzsche?

Someone had said that if you gazed into the abyss, you became the abyss yourself.

Song understood that now, but too late. Everything was already too late.

SHWAAAA!

A cold, fierce wind battered him.

Through its howl, he seemed to hear a conversation from a few days ago.

"This."

"Keep it with you. You know how dangerous it is, Director. Expensive, too."

"…You bastard. You're insane."

"Then you'll have to go insane as well. If you want to save your family."

The man had been insane, and it had been an insane conversation.

Song had agonized over it, each day feeling like ten years. Yet in the end, he had never used *it*.

Was that the last thing I did right?

The wind grew fiercer. Song sensed something drawing near in the darkness and closed his eyes.

Crack! Crunch, crunch, crunch!

His long fall ended.

His neck broke first. Then the bones throughout his body shattered.

Then, through his fading consciousness, Song heard something growl.

—Grrrr.

It was the eerie cry of a monster unlike any he had heard before.

He wanted to say something, but the being that had crouched in the abyss for so many years allowed its prey no last words.

CRUNCH!

Darkness came.

Enormous teeth crushed his lifeless body and swallowed his blood.

They swallowed the thing deep in his pocket, too—the thing he had refused to use to the very end, wanting to die a human rather than a monster.

Whoosh.

Darkness itself turned to light and burst forth.

Chapter 581

Whump! BOOM!

A whip of fire lashed the ground. Piled snow melted, and yeti blood boiled. Kim Hwajong's voice came through his clenched teeth as if he were chewing the words before spitting them out.

"Song Cheonwoo, you fucking bastard…"

The old butler's wide-open eyes were fixed on the spot where someone had been lying only seconds ago.

If this was how it was going to end—if that bastard was going to meet a death like this—Hwajong should have killed him with his own hands. But Song Cheonwoo had summoned the last of some unknown strength, thrown himself into the deep crevasse, and met the death he had chosen for himself.

It was too good an end for a traitor. Worse still…

"We've lost an important witness. I'm sorry, Young Master."

"No."

Choi Minwoo shook his head at Kim Hwajong's sigh-like murmur. His gaze remained fixed on the crevasse whose depth could not be estimated.

"You have nothing to apologize for, Butler Kim. I should have been more careful."

Victory dulled vigilance. Perhaps all the more so after a fight that had been anything but easy. Choi poured the potion—still more than three-quarters full—over himself.

Hiss.

The sound of flesh burning filled the air as his wounds began to close little by little. Feeling a faint pain, he continued.

"Song Cheonwoo must have thought this was the only way to save his family."

"…"

"I understand his situation, but… he must have been more desperate than we realized."

Kim Hwajong muttered roughly, "Damn fool. There wasn't even any guarantee this would save his family. Why do it?"

"He must have been that afraid. People cling to hope even in despair, don't they?"

Choi answered quietly and took his eyes off the crevasse. He could not tell exactly how deep it was, but the drop had to be hundreds of meters.[2663] Song had already been at death's door. His chances of surviving the fall were close to zero.

"We should call the Guild members. No—it would be faster to have the Guild House send people."

[2663] Hundreds of meters is roughly hundreds to thousands of feet; 100 m is about 328 ft.

After more than twenty years together, Kim Hwajong knew at once what he meant.

"You want to recover his body?"

"I don't know if we can, but we have to try. Song Cheonwoo is still Ares Guild's European regional branch director."

Death would not erase his position. If they could prove even half of what had happened here, the repercussions would reach beyond the impregnable fortress that was Ares Guild and shake Go Jun himself.

"Attempted murder, murder-for-hire—whatever the charge, it will stain even Ares Guild's Vice Guild Master. Especially now."

A fortress built through decades of effort did not crumble easily. But Go Jun was different. Choi Minwoo intended to use every bit of power at his disposal to unseat him as lord of that fortress.

"We're going to be busier than ever. Both of us."

Kim Hwajong smiled with pride.

"I've been waiting for this day."

"I'm glad. That you're always at my side."

"Then put me to work before I get any older, Young Master. We'll make that bastard Go Jun regret doing this."

"That's the plan."

Choi nodded and walked away from the crevasse. Whether from his fierce fight with Song or the blood he had lost, exhaustion swept through him and made every step heavy.

Then, as his consciousness gradually grew hazy and he retraced the path he had taken, Choi Minwoo came to an abrupt stop.

Splash.

Muddy water mixed with snow and blood sprayed around him. Kim Hwajong, who had been following behind him, asked in confusion,

"Young Master?"

Choi Minwoo did not answer. He silently stared down at his foot, half-submerged in a puddle of murky water, then suddenly muttered,

"Regret."

"Yes?"

"You said we'd make Go Jun regret doing this."

"I did. Is there a problem…?"

"We left out *why*. Why did Go Jun do it?"

Choi looked at the puddle. A single step had splashed the water and sent ripples across it. Why, then, had Go Jun sent Song Cheonwoo, a member of Ares Guild, to assassinate him?

Because Song was powerful? Because he was a traitor?

Neither.

It's a trap.

The thought struck like lightning. Choi began to tremble.

Not from the shock of his realization, and certainly not from exhaustion.

No. His body was not the only thing that had been trembling from the beginning.

Rumble…

Fresh ripples spread across the puddle as it was settling, and a heap of snow that had yet to melt collapsed. The ground was shaking. Terrified yetis cried out across the trembling mountain.

At the center of it all came a tremendous rumble.

Crack—RUMBLE, RUMBLE!

Choi and Kim Hwajong turned together. The ground split in a spiderweb of cracks, thin fractures running back toward the darkness behind them.

Crack! Crack-crack-crack!

The crevasse.

An enormous darkness whose end could not be seen opened its jaws. Darkness poured from the widening gap.

Darkness—no. Immense magical power shook the mountain and tore through space-time.

SHWAAAA!

And the two men saw what lay beyond the split in space: a boundless blue sky and buildings.

The world they had lived in. The world they were meant to go on living in.

"…Monster Wave."

Two worlds that touched but should never have been connected had become linked. A roar announcing the beginning of the disaster reverberated in every direction.

—GRAAAAAAAH!

Facing the abyss as it finally revealed itself, Kim Hwajong stepped in front of his young master, his gaze darker than ever.

Step.

A snowstorm swept around them. Blackened by magical power, it was no longer white—or beautiful.

"Team Leader, how about a drink?"

A team member came over with a soju[2664] bottle and an easy grin. The Team Leader answered curtly.

"No, asshole."

Despite his words, his glass was already being raised ever so slightly. The team member grinned as if he knew everything and filled the empty glass.

Glug, glug, glug.

The Team Leader threw back the full glass in one gulp, then dipped a piece of flounder sashimi deep in the spicy-sweet sauce and swallowed it. The chewy bite lifted his mood a little.

"…Shit. At least it tastes good."

"Right? This place is famous in the Hunter community."

"Really?"

"Yeah. Search for it and you'll find plenty of reviews. People say it's perfect for a drink after a raid."

"Of course the drinks taste good to them. They finish a raid and pick up plenty of Magic Gems. They didn't come away empty-handed like me."

"…Oh, boy. Here he goes again."

The Team Leader smacked his lips. If he belonged to a Guild, it would hardly matter whether a raid came to nothing. But he led a freelance Hunter team. That meant paying the daily wages of everyone laughing and chatting around him, even if the money had to come out of his own pocket.

Including this shameless bastard who had come over to him.

"You're not mad, are you, Team Leader?"

"Forget it, punk. Pour me another."

"Yes, sir."

The team member snapped a salute and poured. The Team Leader gave a quiet laugh and looked out beyond the railing.

The raid had fallen through, but drinking while looking over the landscape, white from a recent snowfall, was not so bad.

Pyeongchang really does have nice scenery. The scenery, anyway.

That was probably why they had built so many ski resorts around here.

He kept emptying his glass as he took in the view. The crowds at the ski resort and the gondolas running nonstop up and down the mountain showed just how little sense those people had.

"Hey. Isn't this funny?"

The team member looked up from the sashimi he had been devouring.

"What is?"

[2664] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

“There’s a Gate right up on that mountain, and magical power has risen by seven percent. They’re still out there doing this shit.”

Worse, when he came down and checked the news, he had learned that a Monster Wave had broken out in Busan. The Team Leader shook his head.

“Then again, when COVID broke out while I was a kid, there were idiots who still went skiing.”

“Melona?”[2665]

“…Never mind. Just keep stuffing your face.”

He sighed and drained his glass. Thinking about what must be happening in Busan made his chest tighten.

“Uh—uh-oh! Oh, whoa! Whoa, whoa, whoa!”

“What?”

“…Why is she doing that again?”

Everyone turned toward the outburst. A female Hunter in her twenties, who had been deep in thought for a while, was waving her smartphone wildly.

“Wow! No way! This is insane!”

The Team Leader looked at her with concern.

“Yeah. Seems like it.”

“No, not that! I told you earlier, didn’t I? I thought I recognized that masked, incredibly handsome guy up there!”

The Team Leader recalled the Hunters they had encountered, particularly the young man at the back.

“Yeah. Thanks to them, our raid was a bust.”

“But it’s him! Wow, that’s incredible. Kim Sohye, how did you spot him? Are your eyes really that good?”

“I’m about to lose my mind listening to you. Could you please tell me what you’re talking about?”

“Look! Right here!”

She thrust the phone in front of his face. He frowned, then saw the face on the screen and opened his eyes wide.

“What the hell? Is this for real? They do look alike, I guess…”

“I’m telling you, it’s him! You don’t trust me, Team Leader?”

“No.”

“Ah, damn it! This time I’m certain, so believe me! I’ve got an eye for this that I honed through thirty years of idol fandom!”

“You’re twenty-five. Was your father a fan too?”

“Anyway, I’m right! If I’m wrong, you don’t have to pay me today!”

[2665] Melona is a Korean melon-flavored ice cream bar; its name echoes “Corona” in the original wordplay.

A slave to capitalism had put her day's wages on the line. Only then did the Team Leader start to believe her. He was curious, too.

If it's true… why would someone that important come all the way here?

Beside a face handsome enough to belong to a celebrity, the phone displayed a short article.

> **Peace Guild Team Leader Choi Minwoo:** "The Emergency Rescue Team Is for Everyone"

A big shot. A *very* big shot.

The Team Leader had not seen the masked man's face clearly, but the calm eyes and distinctive air in the photograph did seem familiar.

If it really was him, the other Hunters must be Peace Guild members too.

Choi Minwoo had become famous enough recently that the Team Leader had heard about him several times. But even if only half of those stories were true, the man should have been too busy to breathe. Why would he lead his Guild members to a B-grade Gate in Pyeongchang?

Wait. Then that older man I saw on the way down…

Before he could finish the thought—

RUMBLE, RUMBLE, RUMBLE!

A tremendous vibration began to sweep through the area. For an instant, every sound fell silent, and everyone turned their heads in the same direction as if they had planned it.

The Team Leader noticed what was wrong first. He had already been looking there before the shaking began.

…That place…

The place he had climbed toward with such high hopes, only to come back down empty-handed.

The B-grade Gate known as Yeti's Winter Range.

The next moment, what appeared in the Team Leader's widened eyes was part of the mountain slowly collapsing, with pitch-black darkness settling over it. Amid the wreckage of collapsing gondolas and buildings, a dreadful roar shook him to his core.

—GRAAAAAAAH!

A Monster Wave.

And there were still people inside the Gate.

Overcome by suffocating terror, the Team Leader forced out a voice he had barely managed to squeeze together.

"Report it! Right now!"

A frightened question came back.
“W-where?”
“The Hunter Association, the Peace Guild, Jin Taekyung—anywhere! Right now!”

Chapter 582

What could they call it?

Choi Minwoo, Kim Hwajong, and the twenty elite Peace Guild Hunters guarding the Gate from outside all had the same question. None of them could answer it.

They could only stare in disbelief at *it*, now standing in their world.

—GRAAAAAAAH!

A thunderous roar shook the sky.

It was a hippopotamus, an elephant, an ox, and a rhinoceros all at once. Yet it was none of them.

It was too enormous, too powerful, to be called a beast.

Whoooosh. CRUNCH!

A single step—and the impact was tremendous.

Its huge foreleg crushed the Gate control station beneath a shadow that stretched more than ten meters[2666] in every direction. The ground shook as if an earthquake had struck. The cable running down the mountain snapped, and a gondola fell.

Then, from a memory long buried, Kim Hwajong recalled a monster's name.

"…Behemoth."

Behemoth. Or Behemos.

A monster whose name came from the Hebrew word for "beast." Traces of the mythical creature that had risen from the deep, dark abyss could even be found in the Bible.

> Look at Behemoth. Just as I made you, I made it too.
>
> It grazes grass like an ox.

But the Bible was wrong.

Kim Hwajong did not know what being had made the monster before him, but Behemoth was nothing like a peaceful creature that grazed on grass and drank from ponds.

CRUNCH! CRRRUNCH!

—Kwooh! Kwoooooh!

Behemoth was not the only thing to emerge from the Gate.

Some two hundred yetis fled into the world, their cries sounding like screams. They were Behemoth's first targets.

The enormous creature trampled and devoured them without mercy, though they were both its kind and its subordinates.

[2666] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

SHAAK! Thud-thud-thud!

Blue blood fell like rain.

Four legs like temple pillars stamped across the earth. Each time tusks resembling an elephant's ivory scraped the ground, severed monster limbs and blood flew into the air.

A trembling voice escaped someone's lips.

"T-This…"

The sight alone was enough to bring despair.

Everyone stood frozen, staring blankly as the yetis met their gruesome deaths.

Then—

FWOOOOSH!

Beyond the black mist that had settled around them, dazzling light surged upward. Its warmth pushed back the mist, spreading little by little.

Only then did the onlookers release the breaths they had been holding and search for its source.

Twenty-odd pairs of eyes found a young man holding a sword that blazed with light. His own eyes shone brighter than ever.

"Everyone, behind me."

"…!"

The moment his calm voice reached them, the Peace Guild Hunters realized they had broken free of the Fear emanating from Behemoth.

And one person watching the scene trembled with emotion.

This is…

The feeling was deeply familiar and achingly distant. Kim Hwajong remembered a face whose features had grown faint with time and murmured, "So you were here."

Past and present overlapped. What Kim Hwajong saw reflected in his eyes was Cheon Taemin and Choi Minwoo at the same time—and Choi Minwoo and Cheon Taemin at the same time.

Song Cheonwoo had seen the same thing and felt despair. But even in this perilous moment, joy welled up from deep within the old butler's chest.

He took his place beside the young man, who had stood alone in the light.

FWOOSH!

Long, fierce whips of flame formed in his hands. Choi Minwoo met his gaze, his expression composed.

"We have to stop it. No matter what it takes."

There was no retreat in his voice. Below them, screams were already rising from those who had noticed what was happening.

"Aaaah!"

"A-Aaaah!"

—GRAAAAAAAH!

As Behemoth slaughtered the yetis, its roar sent the snow piled on the mountain sliding down like a wave.

More than a thousand people were scattering in every direction, their shrill screams carrying up the slope. Even if luck let them escape the monster for now, they would be its next targets.

Choi Minwoo, Kim Hwajong, and the Peace Guild Hunters knew it. They also knew they could not take on the monster by themselves.

"T-Team Leader."

They all possessed the strength of high-level Hunters, but their opponent was a monster that appeared only in mythology.

Choi Minwoo answered the frightened voice.

"I won't force you. If you want to run, run."

Before anyone could begin to murmur, he continued quietly.

"But don't forget the choice you made here. Ask yourselves whether you can still call yourselves Hunters."

"…!"

The wavering in their eyes stopped. The sword in Choi Minwoo's hand shone brighter than ever.

[Hero's Soul]. An ego sword that granted power worthy of a hero only to those who qualified.

Hummm. Fwoooosh.

The blade shook fiercely. Light burst from it in a flash, driving back the darkness, and its warmth enveloped them all.

By then, Choi Minwoo's eyes had turned golden. Reflected in them was Behemoth, which had finished devouring every last one of its kind.

"Wasn't the power we received given to us for a day like this?"

Not one person here was an exception. Each had been chosen one day by someone unknown and given power beyond the ordinary.

And that power came with duty and a sense of responsibility.

Hunters.

Swords that defended humanity. Shields against the threats it faced. Guardians who had to stand at the forefront of every battle against monsters.

Their wealth and fame might have dulled that ideal, but its pure essence remained.

"Attack formation. Take your positions."

Step.

Choi Minwoo advanced. The light moved with him, and Kim Hwajong and the twenty Hunters followed.

They formed an arrowhead as they approached. Their figures appeared in the enormous eyes of the monster that had just finished its first meal in this new world.

—G. R. A. A. A. A. H.

Behemoth let out a cry that sounded almost like a sneer. Though it had devoured hundreds of yetis, it was still hungry—ready to trample, chew, and swallow the humans approaching it with their irritating light.

—Come. Hu. Mans.

No one there understood Behemoth's Demon Realm language.

But its meaning reached them all.

Shing. Fwoosh.

Weapons were drawn. Magic surged up through staffs and hands.

Twenty-two Hunters shone in the deep darkness, bathed in the sword's radiance. They were drawn taut as a bowstring, and Choi Minwoo's shout loosed them.

"Charge!"

Their battle cry was loud enough to leave their ears ringing. Together, they shot forward as a single arrow.

SHWAAAAAAK!

A streak of light cut through the darkness. At its tip, the monster roared as if the sound had been dragged up from the abyss.

—KWOAAAAAAH!

The next moment—

BOOOOM! CRRRUNCH!

Shouts and roars, light and darkness, collided.

—Kik!

"Shut your mouth, you fucking bastard."

Wham!

The Merman's head vanished with a heavy impact.

I didn't bother checking whether it was dead. Before the body hit the ground, I launched myself forward and cut off the fleeing Mermen.

"You shit all over the place, and now you're running? What kind of business ethics is that? Huh?"

—K-Kiiik.

Their cries were desperate pleas to live. Too late. They were monsters, and I was human.

Besides, if they had crawled all the way to Busan and shit everywhere, they had to pay compensation for it.

An eye for an eye. A life for a life.

I swung White Flame without hesitation.

Whoosh!

Flames surged along the spearhead and swept sideways.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail. The fire dragon's tail, packed with immense heat, lashed some fifty Mermen in a single stroke. Screams rose with the horrific stench of burning flesh.

—KIEEEEEEK!

A pitiful death cry.

I flashed past the nearest Merman.

Slice.

Through my heightened senses, I felt its head lift into the air and heard the faint sound of the cut.

But I wasn't done.

Some five hundred Mermen had gathered here, looking for a way out. That meant some five hundred monsters I had to kill.

Slice. Slice. Shhhhhk!

Limbs flew amid sprays of blood. Everything in my spear's path was severed. From my outstretched palm burst the force of Flame Divine Palm, burning some twenty Mermen.

Fwoosh! KRAAAASH!

It was hot.

The asphalt melting under the extreme heat was hot. So were the tires of the car spinning uselessly after slamming into the side of a bus.

And my heart, as I looked at the driver dead behind the wheel, his foot still on the accelerator.

Drip. Drip.

Blood ran down the hood from the shattered windshield. Even a state-of-the-art airbag had apparently failed to stop the trident that had pierced the glass and lodged in the driver's chest.

The middle-aged man's eyes were empty, their light gone. A family photograph hung from the rearview mirror like a talisman, soaked in blood.

Middle-aged parents. A boy who looked to be in elementary school, and a girl who looked younger still.

The worst fucking part was that everyone in the photograph was inside the car. None of them was smiling anymore. All of them were covered in blood.

"You fucking bastards!"

Fwoosh! KRAAAASH!

The flames blazed fiercer and swallowed the monsters.

I cut through the path they made, swinging my spear. I cut, split, tore, and smashed without stopping.

Amid the heat and the evaporating blood, a thought came to me.

Maybe.

Maybe they had been on a trip too. Maybe this was their first family trip to Busan in years, and they had been laughing and chatting when the monsters appeared.

Maybe the father and son had looked toward nearby Gwangan Bridge and made a promise they would never get to keep.

Crack!

My fist punched through hard scales and crushed bone and flesh.

I watched the Merman silently as it let out a short groan. Then I grabbed the warm, pulpy thing my hand had touched and tore it out.

SPURT! Thud!

Green blood splashed across my face as I pulled my hand out. The stench was horrific, but I was already drenched in blood.

Eyes wide, I dropped the heart I had just ripped out onto the fallen Merman's body.

Plop.

I didn't like the disbelief in its eyes or the look on its face, as though it thought it had been wronged. So I stomped on it.

CRUNCH. Pop.

Only then did I realize no more monsters were coming at me. None were fleeing. None were alive.

I stood in a pool of green blood, breathing hard, when—

"…Wicked human. You."

"Why?"

The Skeleton King met my eyes as I turned. It sighed.

"No. Never mind."

For a moment, I wondered what I looked like to it. I didn't ask. The eyes of the hundred or so Hunters behind it gave me a fair idea.

"We're done here."

At the dry voice that sounded strangely unfamiliar even to me, a Hunter who appeared to be a superior jolted and answered, "Huh? Ah, yes. Yes."

"How are things elsewhere?"

“T-Those were the last ones. We were gathering our forces to hit them all at once, but…”

Gulp.

He swallowed and went on.

“It looks like everything has been taken care of.”

“Good, then. You worked hard too.”

I patted the Skeleton King’s shoulder and started walking again. When someone asked where I was going, I answered briefly.

“To save people. The ones dying right now. The ones who’ve survived this long.”

I was tired—more mentally than physically. But I couldn’t rest.

Somewhere, people were still waiting for rescue, facing the terror of death. I had to save at least one of them.

And then—

Splash.

My foot left a print of green blood on the city asphalt.

Bzzzt. Bzzzt.

An irritating electronic buzz sounded, and a billboard high on a building flickered. Through the static appeared a familiar face.

A face so handsome it was almost irritating.

Team Leader Choi.

A small inset image appeared beside him, along with a caption.

> **Peace Guild Hunter Choi Minwoo. Caught up in the Monster Wave in Pyeongchang…**

God fucking damn it.

Chapter 583

Team Leader Choi. Pyeongchang. Monster Wave.

The three words hit me all at once, leaving my thoughts in a jumble.

But the footage filling the electronic billboard gave me no time to think.

—Kwooooom!

“Aaaahhh!”

“An avalanche!”

People fled, screaming.

They hadn’t even thought to take off their ski equipment. They waddled forward, stumbled, and fell as a vast mass of snow and shattered rock came pouring down behind them.

—BOOOM!

The snow swept over dozens of people like a wave. Blood sprayed amid the thunderous roar.

A building crushed by the falling rock went up in flames. Beyond the surging fire lay the source of it all.

—Ruuuumble!

The sun had not yet set, but the sky above that place was dark.

Black clouds hung over a mountain peak I didn’t recognize. Each flash of dazzling light between them brought a tremendous tremor and a deafening boom.

A Monster Wave.

I knew it instinctively. Where light and darkness met, a battle was deciding the fate of thousands.

And Team Leader Choi, Butler Kim, and the Peace Guild Hunters were risking their lives against a named monster.

An announcer’s voice came through the static.

“The government has declared the Pyeongchang area of Gyeonggi Province a disaster zone and dispatched emergency support forces. Meanwhile, the Monster Wave in Busan…”

I had no reason to listen any longer. No time, either.

I spun toward the Hunters staring blankly at the billboard high on the building and shouted.

“Mages!”

“Y-Yes?”

“Mages, step forward! We have to get to Pyeongchang with Teleport! Right now!”

My shout, charged with internal energy, jolted them as though they’d woken from a nightmare. A few raised their hands hesitantly.

One A-grade mage and six B-grade mages. But their faces were grim.

“I-I’m sorry, but it would be difficult for us to cast Teleport on our own.”

“What?”

“We’ve all just fought monsters. Our mana fatigue is severe, and we’d have to draw a Teleport magic circle. Under these circumstances…”

Their voices trailed off as they looked around.

Victims’ bodies and monster carcasses lay everywhere. The roads had been torn apart.

Teleport was notoriously difficult even for high-ranking mages. These were about the worst conditions imaginable for casting it.

Skeleton King had been watching. Now he spoke, his face twisted.

“You stupid hu—bastards. Do you think this is the time to worry about conditions? Do it. Please? Fuck. Being polite is hard.”

He was barely holding back his anger, but the menacing aura leaking from him made the mages swallow hard.

“B-But we can’t help it. It’s too dangerous.”

“We can’t do it. Even if we somehow succeeded, it’s over 250 kilometers[2667] from Busan to Pyeongchang. We can’t cover that distance in a single jump.”

“Try! Just find some way to try!”

Skeleton King had said exactly what I wanted to say.

But I knew the mages weren’t making excuses. They weren’t Magic Johnson.

The dark-skinned Grand Mage who had sent me into a chaotic battlefield in Sichuan, China, without even a magic circle was probably on another continent by now.

Damn it.

Sticky blood dripped from my clenched fist. I couldn’t tell if it was mine or a monster’s. Maybe both.

“Is there another way?”

A middle-aged Hunter who seemed to be the highest-ranking one there answered anxiously.

“We contacted headquarters a little while ago. They’re looking for a high-ranking mage in Busan who can cast Teleport, but…”

His voice trailed off. His face was grim.

That told me enough. I urged him again to hurry, then clenched my teeth.

Damn it.

Their opponent was a named monster. One as powerful as the Kraken, or worse.

[2667] 250 kilometers is about 155 miles.

How much longer could they hold out against a monster whose might was conveyed even through the footage? How many of them would survive?

Just a little longer. Please, hold out a little longer.

I made the plea silently, knowing it would never reach them, and sat down cross-legged.

Until they found a mage, I needed to recover whatever strength I could.

"Whew."

I closed my eyes and tried to calm the anxiety and rage boiling inside me. Darkness filled my vision.

Through it flashed the faces of those fighting in a darkness deeper still.

Please… survive.

Until I get there.

Whoooosh.

Powerful internal energy, carrying my desperate wish, spread through every limb and bone.

The trunk swept through the air, long and enormous.

Like an elephant's, it knocked aside the incoming spells and arrows, then came hurtling toward the ground.

Whoooosh!

A deep shadow fell across the people below. Choi Minwoo gritted his teeth, sprang forward, and shouted.

"Scatter!"

Fwap-fwap-fwap!

Figures leaped like the wind and scattered in every direction. They moved like the high-ranking Hunters they were, at the top of the Hunter hierarchy.

But if they were A-grade Hunters, the enemy before them was a named monster out of ancient myth.

—GRAAAAAAAH!

Behemoth.

The monster that had risen from the depths of the abyss into the mortal world roared. Its powerful Fear seized souls and stilled movement, shaking the Hunters as they fled.

"Gasp!"

"Hk…!"

Two Peace Guild Hunters had strayed beyond the light of **Hero's Soul**. They caught their breath sharply.

Without their extensive combat experience and strong wills, they might have fainted or gone mad on the spot.

But even the momentary chaos brought on by Fear was enough for the cunning monster to achieve the result it wanted.

“No!”

Behemoth moved half a beat before Choi Minwoo’s warning. That was enough to seal their fate.

Whoom—CRUNCH!

A gust of wind erupted from empty air and slammed into the earth.

Their armor bore high-level defensive magic. Their muscles had been trained to their limits, and their vitality was tenacious.

None of it could withstand the blow. It broke and crushed everything.

“Ghk. Cough!”

Dark red blood burst out with their dying cries. Bones, flesh, even their organs had ruptured. Not even a top-grade potion could save them.

For an instant, Choi Minwoo met both pairs of fading eyes. He gritted his teeth.

Again…!

They had died. Died, and died again.

Trampled beneath enormous forefeet. Impaled on tusks. Crushed by that swinging trunk.

Of the twenty-two Hunters, including himself and Kim Hwajong, more than half had died horribly. Without the potions they’d brought, he would have watched even more of them die.

And now the potions were nearly gone.

Damn it.

Choi Minwoo clenched his teeth. The ache from a broken molar had faded without his noticing. He could no longer feel the blood running from his split lip.

Only anger and determination remained.

They kept him from collapsing in despair. They drove him past his fear and toward Behemoth.

“Young Master!”

Whoosh!

Kim Hwajong’s anguished cry fell behind him as he kicked off the ground, mana surging through his steps.

He shot forward like a ray of light. Something split the air above his head, and Choi Minwoo twisted aside with all his strength.

Whoom—BOOOM!

The ground shook. Snow scattered, and shards of rock scraped his forehead. Red blood ran across his vision. The sword gripped in both hands blazed with pure white light.

Fwoooosh—slash!

The thick darkness split.

A streak of light cut through the air and slashed Behemoth's two pillar-like forelegs. Green blood gushed from the deep wounds.

Fwoooosh!

Drenched from head to toe, Choi Minwoo let out the breath he'd been holding.

He wanted to dodge the blood, but he couldn't. His body shook from the strength he had spent in that brief attack, much like Behemoth's staggering legs.

"Two of its four legs…"

He murmured through a vision stained entirely green.

Fifteen Hunters. Far too high a price compared with his own life.

Still, Behemoth's scream of pain was not unpleasant to hear.

—GRAAAAAAAH! "Hu. Man!"

"…I hear you. No idea what you're saying, though."

Choi Minwoo's answer came out weak.

The pain and exhaustion he'd pushed aside rushed back at once. The light of **Hero's Soul** in his hands was fading, ready to go out.

Hold on a little longer. Just a little longer.

But that was asking too much.

His fatigue had been building since his bloody fight with Song Cheonwoo. With the healer dead and the potions gone, there was nothing to stop the bleeding or tend his injuries. They were finally bringing him down.

Ssssh.

The world tilted.

No. The world wasn't tilting.

Choi Minwoo was.

As his view slowly turned over, he saw something enormous flying toward him.

Whoooosh!

He felt the wind of a blow that would crush his entire body, and closed his eyes.

BOOOM!

With a thunderous crash, the only light vanished.

A cloud of snow and dirt rose through the dense black fog.

Ruuumble!

Behemoth's strongest blow yet shook the entire mountain.

The surviving Peace Guild Hunters stared in despair. What little hope they had held onto had vanished with the light.

With the young man who had led them.

It's over. All of it.

They all knew.

The world itself might not end, but the world they knew would end here today.

Strangely, they felt calm as they faced it.

They had done their duty, at least. Their duty as people and as Hunters. They had given everything to a sense of purpose that wealth and fame had made them forget for a while.

They had no regrets.

"Fuck. I signed the contract on my house two days ago."

A snort of laughter escaped the Hunters at someone's mutter.

"Crazy bastard."

"If you're scared, go. Nobody's stopping you."

But no one moved. Not even the Hunter who had spoken first.

He looked down at his trembling legs and said bluntly, "How are we supposed to leave? I'd rather die fighting."

They all felt the same. Thousands of people were still evacuating behind them.

The comrades who had fallen, and Choi Minwoo, who had charged Behemoth to the end, had died protecting those people.

"We've got money, and we've got pride."

"Still, what a shitty day to die. Can't even see the sky through this fucking fog."

"Why'd that elephant bastard suddenly stop moving?"

The few who remained steeled themselves to charge Behemoth. Just as they were about to rush forward, a quiet voice spoke.

"You needn't die."

At the quiet voice, the thick fog parted. It was fire, not light, that drove back the abyssal darkness.

Fwoooosh!

A man appeared through the fog amid fierce flames and continued,

"At least, you don't."

The Hunters' trembling eyes took in a middle-aged man with half-gray hair.

Kim Hwajong had disappeared into the fog after Choi Minwoo. He looked very different now.

"…Guild Master. Your arm."

"I'm fine."

His left arm had been torn off. Even so, Kim Hwajong smiled faintly through his exhaustion.

He had lost an arm, but he had saved something far more precious.

He passed the person cradled in his right arm to the Hunters.

“Leave this place at once. Take the Young Master with you.”

“B-But…”

“That’s an order from your Guild Master.”

Grrrrr.

The monster gave a low laugh. It had spotted the prey that had escaped it by a hair.

Kim Hwajong’s smile disappeared.

“Go!”

“…!”

The force of his shout left the Hunters no room to argue. They clenched their teeth, took Choi Minwoo’s limp body, and gave a brief bow before launching themselves down the steep slope.

Shhhh-shhhh-shhk!

Kim Hwajong watched them slide away. A faint smile returned to his lips.

You must make it out safely. You must.

When he turned away after murmuring the small plea that would never reach them, hellfire flickered in his one remaining hand.

“Come on, you fucking bastard.”

—GRAAAAAAAH!

Behemoth’s enormous eyes and Kim Hwajong’s flame-filled gaze collided in midair.

The old butler had sent everyone away and stood alone at the edge of the cliff. He began to recite what might be his final spell.

“Hellfire of the underworld, descend upon this place.”

Hell Fire.

Ruuuuumble!

Chapter 584

Ruuuuumble!

A pillar of fire shot into the sky. The mountain shook. For hundreds of meters[2668] in every direction, the air boiled with heat so intense that snow, dirt, and rock melted away.

Lava flowed across a land of death. Above the ground where everything else had evaporated, two figures stood like towers.

—Hu. Man. How. Dare. You!

The mythical monster raged, its body charred black. The half-gray-haired old butler regarded it calmly.

Hell Fire.

Even the hellfire summoned from the depths of hell had failed to bring Behemoth down. One of its enormous tusks had melted away without a trace, and its entire body was charred black, but the monster remained standing.

And yet…

“You’re a tough bastard.”

Kim Hwajong did not retreat. He could not.

He tightened his grip on his Magic Staff with his one remaining hand.

Fwoosh.

Flames engulfed the short, slender staff. When they passed, the staff that emerged was longer and thicker.

It was the cherished weapon with which he had reduced countless monsters to ash during the chaotic years of the Great Cataclysm—the weapon that had earned its master the name Hellfire Mage.

Kim Hwajong pointed the reddish staff at Behemoth and muttered,

“Stop. You’re not going anywhere.”

—Old. Man!

Behemoth roared. The black mist hanging over the area stirred like a living creature and shot toward Kim Hwajong.

Sssshhhh!

It was a rope that could bind his whole body and a blade that could tear through flesh and crush it.

Kim Hwajong watched it close in from every direction. Then the staff in his bloodied hand struck the ground.

BOOM!

[2668] One meter is about 3.28 ft; hundreds of meters span hundreds to thousands of feet.

A deep rumble sent a wave spreading outward. Flames rose around Kim Hwajong and joined into a single ring.

Fwoosh—FWOOSH!

Before fire was a symbol of destruction, it was a force of purification.

The instant the black mist touched the flames, it crumbled away like ash.

The enormous eyes of the monster looking down upon the earth reflected the figure of a lone human standing tall.

—What. Is. This?

Even Behemoth had not expected it.

Its opponent was a mere human. Yet the small, insignificant creature had wounded it—and now had nullified its attack.

—You. Hu. Man!

A roar laden with powerful Fear shook the entire area. But though fire flickered in Kim Hwajong's eyes, his heart was utterly calm.

The monster had misjudged one thing.

It did not realize that the old human standing before it possessed none of the fear that everyone carried deep in their hearts.

I'm glad, Young Master.

Kim Hwajong smiled at the words that would never reach him. His only fear was moving farther from this disaster even now.

As long as that child, Choi Minwoo, could survive… it did not matter what happened to him.

Even if I die here.

He could be crushed beneath the monster's feet, impaled on its tusks and killed without a final word, or reduced to ash after wringing every last bit of strength from his body and mana. It would be all right.

If the Young Master is safe, that is enough for me.

Kim Hwajong gripped his staff with a glad heart.

Mana poured into the tip of his reddish weapon in an amount that had already pushed him beyond his limits. It grew hot, then burst forth as flame.

"Sweep it away."

Fire Wave.

At the brief incantation, a wave of fire surged forward.

Behemoth stood in its path. With an enraged cry, it swung its trunk, shaped like an elephant's but dozens of times larger.

FWOOSH!

A powerful rush of wind slammed into the wave of fire. The blistering heat died in an instant, and invisible blades of wind raked everything around them.

Ssshhh-shhk! Slash!

The ground split and tore like paper. Kim Hwajong had already escaped by the narrowest margin.

A low voice escaped between the old butler's lips as he charged toward Behemoth's flank.

"Shoot forth."

Blaze.

BOOM!

Flames burst from the tip of the foot he planted.

The blast sent Kim Hwajong forward like a streak of fire. A dense shadow fell over his head.

Whoooosh!

"…!"

Instinct beat reason by half a step. *Fire Shield.* At the silent, unspoken spell, layer upon layer of fiery shields formed above him.

In the next instant, tremendous pressure crushed down on the more than twenty overlapping shields.

CRRRRUNCH!

They shattered and scattered.

The overwhelming force and weight—and the immense magical power behind them, whose limits he could not begin to fathom—broke through the shields and sent his mana reeling.

Ptooey!

Dark red blood sprayed from Kim Hwajong's lips.

His vision blurred as the spell collapsed. But instead of crumpling where he stood, he clenched his teeth and threw himself aside, almost falling.

CRACK! THUD!

The defensive spell had bought him a moment.

Behemoth's trunk swept past by a hair and smashed into the ground. Hundreds of fragments flew outward, scraping across Kim Hwajong's calf.

The pain felt like a burn. But instead of groaning, the old butler exposed his bloodstained teeth and smiled.

"Didn't I tell you? You're not going anywhere."

His staff gave off searing heat. A sphere of flame appeared in midair and swelled.

Kim Hwajong coughed up blood.

"Burst. Barrage of fire."

Flame Cannon.

Dazzling light-flames erupted as the spell was completed.

The ultimate fire spell, carrying power faster and more formidable than any cannon, shot toward the monster's two forelegs—the same forelegs that Choi Minwoo had already cut halfway through.

—You…!

FWOOSH—BOOOOOOM!

Behemoth's cry vanished beneath a blast that shook the entire area.

The fire that tore through space burst open the wounds that had not yet healed and swept through the inside of the legs.

Sizzle.

Agonizing pain surged from its forelegs, now blackened like charcoal. Behemoth roared.

—GRAAAAAAAAAAH!

Ruuuuumble!

At last, its two forelegs gave way.

The mythical monster that had risen from the abyss into this world dropped to its forelegs like a collapsing temple.

Its immense weight shook the earth. A great cloud of dust rose.

And the man who had brought Behemoth to its knees laughed as he spat blood.

"Ha! Hahahaha!"

It was the laughter of a Hunter once called the greatest fire mage, and the relief of a butler who had done his duty.

That's enough. That's enough.

Half of Behemoth's four legs were useless.

Unless it grew wings, it could no longer pursue Choi Minwoo. No small number of others would survive because of it, too.

Kim Hwajong smiled at the dark shadow flying toward him.

Still, just a little… I wish…

CRACK! Sssshhhh!

His vision flashed white. An enormous blow engulfed him in pain and sent him flying like a cannonball.

BOOM!

With a thunderous crash, his back smashed into solid rock and broke. Something unstoppable surged up from deep inside him.

"Gueeeeeegh!"

The old butler looked down at what he had vomited, the light fading from his eyes. Small pieces of his organs lay in the pool of dark red blood.

His ears felt blocked, as though his eardrums had burst. Through his blurred vision, a memory from long ago rose like a haze.

"Your fire magic is impressive. Were you an arsonist before this?"

"…What kind of crazy shit is that? If you're not going to help, get lost."

"Fortunately, I won't have to 'go out,' then. I'm going to help you and everyone here."[2669]

"Hmm. That changes things. What's your name?"

"Cheon Taemin."

He had not known that this man, who looked absurdly young for his age, would become the idol to whom Kim Hwajong would devote his entire life.

But that became reality soon enough.

One year, two years, five years… By the end of the long, terrible Great War, Kim Hwajong had become Cheon Taemin's shadow.

"What am I supposed to do now?"

The Great Cataclysm had changed Kim Hwajong's life completely, just as it had changed so many others. He had waited so long for peace, yet when it finally came, he did not know what to do with himself.

Cheon Taemin answered his question with one of his own.

"What do you want to do?"

"I don't know. But I'll do anything you ask."

"Then join the Guild. I need you. I've brought Jungryong and Cheonwoo in too."

"That Peace Guild thing?"

"Yes."

"The name's pretty damn lame. How about Ares instead? The god of war from Greek mythology. Ares."

"Ares, huh? Not bad. I'll take your suggestion, so join the Guild. I'll make sure you never have to worry about retirement."

"…Office work really doesn't suit me. All right, Guild Master."

"I've told you to call me hyung[2670] about five thousand times over the last five years. You never change."

As Taemin had said, Kim Hwajong never did.

Not even after his relationship with his two trusted comrades and closest sworn brothers grew distant, and after it became difficult to see Cheon Taemin's face.

Peace had come, but Kim Hwajong's fiery temper remained, and he still swore constantly.

He decided to change only after a child born amid everyone's blessings lost both parents in an unexpected accident.

"Hello."

"…Hello."

[2669] The Korean verb translated as "get lost" can also mean "go out," as a flame does.

[2670] *Hyung* is a familiar Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Only a few people had gathered for the funeral. The boy, no more than four or five years old, looked lonely.

He clung to the leg of his maternal grandfather, now his only family, and greeted Kim Hwajong with a somber face. The sight pained the aging man.

Perhaps that was why, when Cheon Taemin came to him a few days later, he accepted without hesitation.

“Could you take care of Minwoo? Of the boy?”

The immortal hero who had become a symbol of humanity was always busy. Even after the Great Cataclysm ended, Cheon Taemin lived as though something were chasing him.

In his place, Kim Hwajong became family to the child left alone.

“Good day, Young Master.”

Neat hair and clothes. A gentle voice. A smile at the corners of his mouth.

That was how the Hellfire Mage, who had set a page of the Great Cataclysm ablaze, became Butler Kim.

“Young Master, you mustn’t run! You’ll hurt yourself—oh dear.”

“Young Master. Being a picky eater is bad for your health. Please eat.”

“Young Master, please don’t cry.”

Young Master. Young Master. Young Master…

Time flowed like a river.

The boy grew into a young man, and white frost settled over Kim Hwajong’s hair.

Even after Cheon Taemin vanished without a trace, Kim Hwajong remained steadfast in his place.

His Young Master no longer ran about recklessly, ate every kind of food without complaint, or cried while thinking of the parents who had left him too soon.

Then, one day, Kim Hwajong saw traces of someone he had not seen in a long time in the grown young man’s face.

“You said you were going to create a Guild.”

“Yes. I’m sorry to ask, Butler Kim, but I need you to serve as Guild Master.”

“If that is what you wish, Young Master, I will do anything. But what do you intend to name the Guild?”

“The Peace Guild. I’m going to call it the Peace Guild.”

“…!”

“Butler Kim, why do you look so… displeased?”

What could he say? So many thoughts came at once that the old butler hesitated. Then he burst out laughing.

“Not at all. The Peace Guild. What a wonderful name.”

And so the past met the present.

From the founding of the Peace Guild onward, Kim Hwajong greeted each day with joy and memories. His Young Master, who had worn a cold, rigid mask, softened after finding “comrades” for the first time in his life. The Guild grew day by day.

Kim Hwajong thought there would be nothing but good days ahead. From then on. Forever.

He thought he would stay beside his Young Master and watch him grow.

Today really was… the best day of my life.

Cough.

Kim Hwajong laughed as he vomited blood mixed with pieces of his organs.

There was only one reason he could laugh as he died: something his Young Master had said to him today.

“Thank you. For becoming my only family.”

And what else had the Young Master said?

“I’ve always wanted to tell you that.”

Yes. That was it.

Kim Hwajong raised his head, coughing. Thick black mist filled his fading vision.

Somewhere beyond it, his only hope—and his only fear—was probably alive and leaving this place.

“I want to… see you.”

The words trembled between his bloodied lips.

The mythical monster smiled in satisfaction at the dying old butler and opened its jaws.

FWOOSH.

A tremendous gust swept through the entire area.

The flames that had yet to go out, someone’s scattered limbs and blood, even the rocks—all were drawn in.

They spun like a tornado inside Behemoth’s mouth.

“Young… Master.”

No. That was not it. Though his words would never reach him, this was his final greeting.

A faint smile touched his wrinkled lips.

“Minwoo.”

At the very moment his fading voice escaped—

Sssshhhh—FLASH!

A burst of light erupted in midair and turned the whole world white.

Chapter 585

Whoooosh!

A fierce rush of air sounded overhead. Thousands of people who had been screaming and fleeing in every direction stopped in their tracks. One tourist looked up at the sky and spoke in a daze.

"…Huh?"

He wasn't the only one wondering.

The civilians fleeing the monster, the hundreds of reinforcements dispatched to stop it, even the Peace Guild Hunters hurrying down the mountain to fulfill their Guild Master's final wish—they all saw it and had the same question.

What is that?

But they saw it from different places and with different eyes. To the civilians, the streak of light crossing the sky was simply a mystery. The high-ranking Hunters among the reinforcements felt a powerful surge of mana far above them for the briefest instant.

Closer still, the Peace Guild Hunters on the mountainside realized how the light had appeared out of thin air.

…Teleport?

Who? How? Why?

Questions raced through countless minds. But no one saw and felt what was happening more clearly than Kim Hwajong.

On the brink of death, the old butler recognized the blue light spreading across the sky, pressing down on the black mist of magical power.

That's…

Power, pure and more destructive than anything else.

Flame. It was flame.

Brighter than sunlight and as fierce as the sun itself, it streaked across the sky. For a moment, a face seemed to pass through Kim Hwajong's blurred vision—a face somewhere inside that blinding light, too bright to look at directly.

Yes. It's you.

His smile deepened. The primordial monster risen from myth opened its enormous jaws toward the oncoming light.

Whooooooom—

The wind split. The air scattered. Inside jaws wide enough to swallow a mountain, an abyssal power churned.

But the light did not stop. It grew sharper and larger, becoming blue-white flame that surged through the air.

Gooooong.

The world stopped. Two forces that swallowed all space and sound as they advanced collided.

And in the next moment, Kim Hwajong could see. He could hear.

Fwooooosh!

Darkness torn to shreds beneath the blue sky.

Blue-white flames burning through everything in their path. And in that dazzling, silent world, one voice ringing clear.

“One Annihilation.”

Space warped. Unprecedented flames fell like a meteor and pierced Behemoth’s jaws before they could close, passing through its body.

As the monster toppled with a death cry like thunder, the old butler forgot his pain and laughed aloud.

Even the greatest master in the world could not escape death. Neither could an ancient monster that belonged in a myth. Not when a full-powered One Annihilation had entered through its mouth and pierced its entire body.

—Ho…w…

Bewilderment and death settled together in the eyes of a monster unlike any I had ever seen or heard of. It stared at me vacantly as its enormous body slowly tipped over.

Krrrrrrrung!

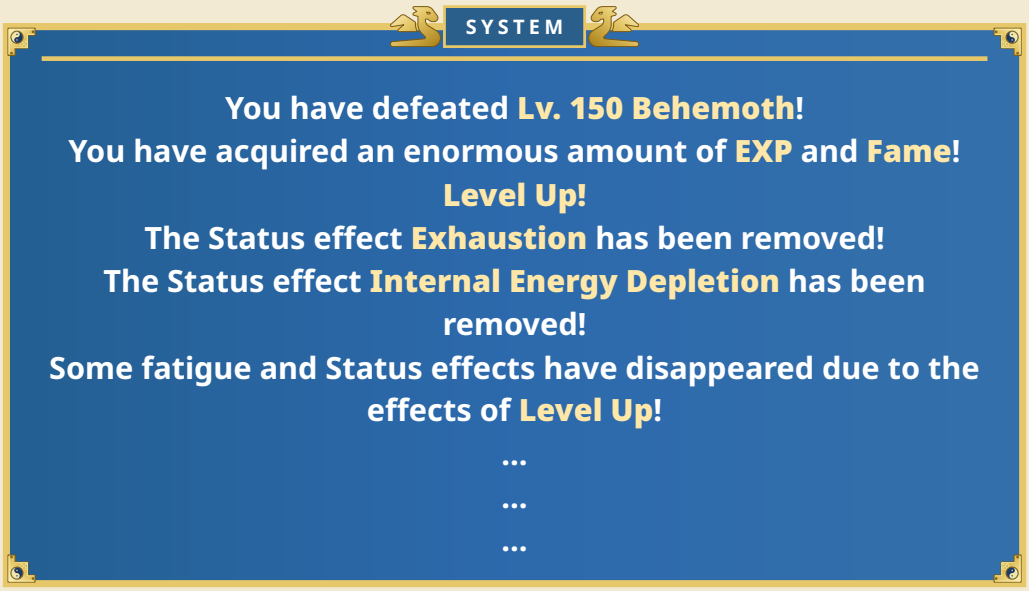
The mountain shook when its lifeless body hit the ground. Huge clouds of dust rose all around me, and I gritted my teeth against the pain and fatigue rolling over me in waves.

I can’t collapse.

One Annihilation was a double-edged sword. It poured out all the user’s strength at once.

But I couldn’t fall yet. Not now. Fortunately, I had a power ordinary people didn’t.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Damn it.

I barely managed to steady myself.

Leveling up was one of the System's most broken features, but unless the effects stacked, it couldn't fix everything. Too much fatigue had built up in my body and mind. The aftereffects of One Annihilation left my hands and feet tingling as if I'd been electrocuted.

Still, I couldn't stop or collapse. I drew on the internal energy that had filled my dantian with the level-up and sent it surging forward.

Boom!

Compressed air burst outward, scattering the dust. At last I could see a rounded shape covered in white bones.

Step. Step.

My heart pounded with every step across the ruined ground. I couldn't hide the fear in my ragged breathing.

I was afraid of what I'd find. Afraid he wouldn't look the way I hoped. Afraid he would say goodbye before I was ready.

Tap. Shrrr...

When I carefully placed my hand against it, the membrane made of bones scattered as though it were melting. And then I could finally see.

Inside was a grim-faced blond foreigner. Leaning against him was a middle-aged man with half-gray hair, each faint breath seeming to be his last.

This is...

For a moment, my heart seemed to stop.

It took only a glance to understand. The top-grade potion bottle lying at the Skeleton King's feet was empty. The man appeared to have recovered without a mark on him, but strength was already draining from his body.

My vision swam.

"…Butler Kim."

His half-closed eyelids fluttered at my voice. When his fading gaze met mine, his bloodstained lips curved into a gentle smile.

"You came."

"…!"

"Yes. I knew it would be you. That light was so warm."

I clenched my teeth to hold back a groan. Butler Kim had already accepted what was happening to him. That was probably why he sounded different.

The man before my eyes was neither Butler Kim nor the Guild Master of the Peace Guild. He was simply a human being, Kim Hwajong, saying goodbye.

But…

I'm not ready yet.

I couldn't accept this sudden farewell. I wasn't going to smile and let him go. I would do anything to bring Kim Hwajong back—to make him Butler Kim, the Guild Master, again.

"But I'm a little cold now. I was so warm before."

I took his hand and slowly sent Scorching Yang Qi into him.

"It's because we're up on the mountain. You'll warm up soon."

"Will I?"

I forced a smile.

"Yes. It's still winter."

As the warmth seeped into him, Kim Hwajong smiled faintly.

"It really is. Just as you said."

"You'll be all right. Don't worry. I'll take care of—"

My voice failed me, and not only because my chest had tightened. The internal energy I'd sent through him had shown me the state of his body.

What in the world…

Everyone was born with innate qi, the root and source of all the body's energy. Almost none remained in Kim Hwajong.

No. Even what little remained was slowly burning away.

Like a dying flame.

Jeok Cheongang's innate qi had been damaged in Henan, but not to this extent. Kim Hwajong's condition was beyond repair.

I could tell from what my internal energy revealed.

What it had taken for him to face Behemoth. What he had sacrificed to hold back the monster that had crawled out of the darkness. And who he had burned his one and only life for.

"Young Master… Minwoo. Is the boy safe?"

I made my voice as bright as I could.

"He's safe. I caught a glimpse of him on the mountainside. He's fine."

"Good. That's good. What a relief."

What's a relief? Look what's happened to you.

I bit my lip rather than say it aloud. Then the Skeleton King's thought sounded in my head.

—I absorbed the magical power that had seeped into his bones and gave him a top-grade potion, but it was already too late. Even I couldn't save him.

I knew. I couldn't blame him when he'd done everything he could. His entire appearance was an illusion made with magic, but the guilt and sorrow on his face were real.

—…I'm sorry, human.

A question occurred to me. It was about everything happening around me.

Why was he the one apologizing? How had Kim Hwajong, who'd eaten with us and laughed with us just a few days ago, ended up lying here beyond recovery?

And why hadn't I stopped it?

Why?

I had power. The power to stop disasters and prevent tragic deaths.

It had started with a mysterious capsule that appeared in my life one day. It let me change the fate I'd been given and meet people who became precious to me. Now one of those bonds was about to break. One of those people was about to leave me.

So why couldn't I stop it?

In Shanxi, Henan, Sichuan, Hubei. In Sichuan, in Busan…

I had saved so many lives while traveling between the Murim and the modern world. So why couldn't I save the one person about to leave before my eyes?

Why?

I was sinking into that question, into helplessness, when—

Ssssh. Tap.

A cold hand covered my trembling fist. Kim Hwajong looked at me, warmth in his eyes.

"It isn't your fault."

"…!"

"You did your best."

His eyes were no longer clouded. His voice no longer sounded ready to fade. The kindness in his face caught the breath in my throat.

The final rally.

A last flame flaring at the edge of death.

No. I couldn’t let him go yet. I gritted my teeth and sent more internal energy into him, but his body was already at its limit. Strength continued to drain away.

More. Just a little more!

I poured every bit of internal energy in my dantian into him. I held his slowly closing acupoints[2671] open and tried to feed the flame dying deep inside his body.

The end came closer rapidly anyway.

“It’s cold. I don’t know if it’s winter, like you said, or if night’s already fallen.”

It couldn’t be either. Scorching Yang Qi was still pouring into him, and the afternoon sun remained in the sky.

Only Kim Hwajong could feel that cold and darkness. Death was freezing his body and drawing a veil over his eyes.

I struggled to speak to the old butler as his breaths grew thinner.

“It’s all right. You’ll see Team Leader Choi soon. Just trust me and…”

Thud.

A hand closed around my wrist. The Skeleton King shook his head, his face grim.

At last I understood. Nothing I said or did could stop this.

It was time to let Kim Hwajong go, so he could leave with whatever peace I could give him.

“Young Master… Minwoo. Is the boy safe?”

His eyes had turned milky. He’d asked me already, but that didn’t matter. I could answer him a hundred times. A thousand.

“He’s safe. Not a hair on his head was harmed.”

“I want to see him. Just once more…”

“You will. He’s already coming.”

“Is that… true?”

“Yes. Ah, there he is.”

It was a lie. A bright red, pure white lie.

On the nameless mountainside swept by a wave of chaos, there were only the three of us and the monster’s corpse.

But Kim Hwajong could no longer tell. With his sight clouded and his mind fading, he reached into empty air as though the person he’d been waiting for would take his hand.

Grab.

At my call and the look that accompanied it, Skeleton King firmly took that hand. The old butler’s eyes curved like crescent moons, and a radiant smile spread across his lips.

“You’ve come.”

[2671] Acupoints are points along the body’s energy channels in traditional East Asian medicine.

And then—

“My grand…son.”

The flame that had burned for one person and refused to go out for this moment finally guttered.

Sssrrk. Tap.

Everything went black.

Chapter 586

Some truths are cruel and cold.

When people face them, they sometimes turn away, unable—or unwilling—to believe what has happened.

Like me right now.

"…Human."

Skeleton King's voice broke the silence. I felt as though I had woken from a long, terrible dream.

And in the next moment, I realized that none of it had been a dream. It was reality.

He's gone. He really is.

Kim Hwajong's face was peaceful in death. Joy still lingered in the smile fixed upon his lips—the smile of a man who had fulfilled his final wish before he left.

But I kept sending Scorching Yang Qi through his body, along with questions that could no longer reach him.

Are you still cold? Is it still dark?

Perhaps the old butler I remembered was wandering an endless winter night even now. Shivering, unable to see an inch ahead, searching the darkness for one person.

I couldn't stop. I had to keep putting warmth into his body as it slowly grew cold.

Thud.

A cold hand came to rest on my shoulder. Skeleton King spoke in a subdued voice.

"Human."

"Let go."

"That is enough. Stop."

He was wrong. It wasn't enough, so I couldn't stop.

Just as I was about to roughly shake off the hand on my shoulder, Skeleton King continued.

"He will not be cold anymore, so let that human go… Let that person rest."

"…!"

Why did the strength leave my body when I heard that?

I didn't know.

Perhaps it was because Skeleton King had spoken respectfully of a human for the first time. Perhaps it was because his voice sounded so unusually weak.

Or perhaps it was because of the people who had returned to this nameless mountainside after disaster had swept through it.

Crunch.

Careful footsteps pressed into the snow.

I turned toward the sound and saw five men and women emerge. I recognized their faces from the greetings we'd exchanged once or twice at the Guild House.

Peace Guild members.

They must have realized the situation had changed and come back.

They had already fought Behemoth desperately ahead of me, exhausting themselves and suffering injuries. With vacant eyes, they stared at the monster collapsed before them. Then they turned their heads and looked in this direction.

And—

"No!"

"Guild Master!"

Shouts and screams rang out together.

They hurried over Behemoth's corpse and found Kim Hwajong in a deep sleep from which he would never wake.

"H-How could this happen?"

"…Damn it. I knew this would happen. I knew it!"

Their voices were filled with grief and tears.

I hadn't been there, but I could picture what had happened.

He must have told them to go. Told them to run with Team Leader Choi because he was all right.

That was the kind of person Kim Hwajong was.

Someone mattered more to him than his own life: a young man he called Young Master and thought of as his grandson.

I had stood there as though nailed to the ground, watching everything. Then I suddenly opened my mouth.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Y-Yes?"

My voice came out rough and hollow, so unfamiliar it might have belonged to someone else.

"Lay Team Leader Choi down beside him."

"…!"

"Hurry."

The Guild members stared at me for a moment, then understood and nodded. They carefully laid Team Leader Choi, unconscious after exhausting all his strength, on the ground.

The two men lay side by side. They looked nothing alike, yet somehow they resembled each other.

You finally met, the two of you.

Without a word, I placed their hands together.

Maybe it was my imagination, but for an instant Kim Hwajong's smile seemed to brighten.

"Hunter Jin Taekyung. Wouldn't it be better to wake the Team Leader…?"

I shook my head at the Guild member who had spoken.

"No."

"B-But…"

"We can't. Not right now."

I cut him off firmly. It wasn't as though I hadn't considered it myself.

If Kim Hwajong had still been alive, I would have done whatever it took to wake Team Leader Choi and let them see each other.

But…

It's too late.

Kim Hwajong was dead. Team Leader Choi's body was battered, and accumulated fatigue had pushed it to its limit. Even if I forced him awake and gave him a potion, the backlash would come down on him several times harder.

So would the grief and rage.

The dead had found peace after their suffering. The living had to carry theirs on.

I'd learned that three years ago. I couldn't wake Team Leader Choi in that condition just to tell him something so cruel.

But I could promise him one thing.

Before Team Leader Choi regained consciousness, I would bring him a gift that could soothe even a little of the rage and grief he would feel.

Whoosh! Slash!

The tip of the spear I swung without any preparation split the air, sending a crescent of Force through Behemoth's enormous body. Skeleton King murmured, almost with a sigh.

"Stop."

I swung again instead of answering.

Once. Twice. Three times…

Slash! Slash! Fwoosh!

The corpse fell into pieces, and the blood left inside it spurted up like a fountain.

The vast magical power Behemoth had once held was gone. Now it was only meat.

I cut through it without hesitation, like a butcher, until Skeleton King could stand it no longer.

"I said stop! What difference do you think this will—"

"It can make enough of a difference. That's why I'm doing this."

"What?"

He stared at me, puzzled.

"What in the world are you talking about?"

I didn't answer. One step carried me several meters[2672], bringing Behemoth's corpse right before me.

I studied the remains, cut so thoroughly that nothing of the monster's former majesty remained. At last, I found what I was looking for.

No—it had made itself known before I found it.

Vrrrr.

A faint vibration passed through the air. With it came a murky, powerful energy.

"...Found it."

I had worried that it might have been erased by the One Annihilation I had fired earlier, but fortunately, *it* was unharmed.

I murmured in relief and reached out without hesitation.

Whoosh. Clack!

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space sent *it* flying into my hand. I stared at it with a solemn gaze.

Item Appraisal.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Behemoth's Turbid Abyss
Type: Magic Gem
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: None
Description: The abyss contained within Behemoth, a Named Monster and primordial beast, and the source of its magical power.
For some reason, it absorbed another source of magical power. Its once-pure darkness became turbid and even more powerful.
Using it requires an extremely demanding and difficult purification process.

My eyes grew hot as I read the System Window floating before me.

But my mind was colder and clearer than ever as it turned over the information.

Behemoth's Turbid Abyss.

The System had never lied to me. Not once. Every word of that description had to be true.

[2672] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

It absorbed another source of magical power. For some reason. I see.

The questions that had been drifting through my head for the past several hours, ever since my conversation with Kraken, began to fall into place one after another.

Who had given Kraken a Magic Gem to cause a Monster Wave? Who had ordered him to do it?

Why had Team Leader Choi, busy as he was, left Seoul for Pyeongchang in Gangwon Province? Why had another Monster Wave happened here, of all places?

And what did the description of Behemoth's Magic Gem mean?

Why? Why? Why?

I asked myself each question and found its answer.

Only a short time passed, though it felt like hours. At last, I had answers to everything.

Everything but the final piece of the puzzle.

Right. One last piece.

I didn't hesitate. I already knew where to find it.

"Why did you come here today?"

I was speaking to the Peace Guild members. Their eyes turned toward a middle-aged Hunter who seemed to be the most senior among them. He answered grimly.

"Team Leader Choi had someone he needed to meet in secret. A man disguised with illusion magic. He looked very anxious."

"Who was he?"

"I'm sorry, but none of us know. I don't know who he was either."

The middle-aged man was probably telling the truth. But I wasn't disappointed.

I had heard the man's identity directly from Team Leader Choi himself not long ago. Even the temporary Head of Security had not been informed.

Song Cheonwoo.

A hero of the Great Cataclysm and Ares Guild's European regional Director.

And the political rival of both Lee Jungryong and his disciple, Go Jun—two generations of enemies.

But I knew Song Cheonwoo and Team Leader Choi had secretly agreed to work together for the time being. I wasn't foolish enough to think Song was behind this.

He had no reason. Not one.

Song Cheonwoo was still ambitious after all these years. Whatever else was going on, the idea that he would try to kill Team Leader Choi—a valuable ally in his effort to bring down Go Jun—made no sense.

Someone else was behind everything that had happened today.

Someone who stood to gain more than anyone from the deaths of those two men.

Someone who could use an S-grade Magic Gem of astronomical value and rarity to cause a Monster Wave.

Go Jun.

The final piece fell into place. I knew what I had to do—and that the consequences of my choice could reach the people around me.

Then…

I slowly closed my eyes.

There was no turning back. Right or wrong, I had to do this.

When I opened my eyes again, neither my resolve nor my voice wavered.

“If Team Leader Choi wakes up while I’m gone, please make sure someone tells him.”

“Pardon? Tell him what…?”

“S-grade Hunter Jin Taekyung…”

The unfamiliar, dry voice that sounded as though it belonged to someone else continued.

“…is leaving the Peace Guild as of this moment.”

“…!”

“…!”

The frozen expressions of the people before me came into view, along with someone’s face twisted in anger.

“You bastard. Don’t tell me you’re—”

“You stay here. Protect the people and the Guild, just in case.”

The one who had to leave would leave. The one who had to stay would stay.

I shook my head at Skeleton King when he tried to stop me again, then asked the Guild members who had gone rigid like statues.

“Anyone here capable of Teleport? Hands up.”

“H-Hand.”

A mage raised his hand without thinking and asked with a dazed expression,

“B-But where to?”

“Jongno. No…”

I looked at the old butler, asleep forever, and finished.

“Let’s go to Ares Guild.”

Chapter 587

The air. Time.

Everything seemed to have stopped.

That was how it felt to the master of Area A, hidden in the strictest secrecy within Ares Guild in Jongno, Seoul.

How?

The question kept circling through Go Jun's mind.

He had forgotten Go Se-won was standing beside him. His face rigid, he stared at the holographic television mounted on the wall.

Live footage from dozens of unmanned reconnaissance drones deployed by the government and various media outlets filled the screen.

"Right now, you're looking at Mount Balwang, near Pyeongchang in Gangwon Province, where the Monster Wave occurred. And…"

It was the voice of the public broadcaster's nine o'clock news anchor. Usually calm and serious, the unseen man sounded highly agitated.

"Can you see this, everyone? That is the corpse of Behemoth, the Named Monster! Around it, survivors of the disaster are being evacuated by emergency helicopter…"

Go Jun's eyelids trembled.

The brutally dismembered corpse of the monster. The survivors. The voices of the Peace Guild members and the anchor explaining the situation.

All of it fed his fury.

Bang!

With a thunderous crash, the latest-model holographic television—replaced more than ten times in the past month—burst into dust.

Go Jun did not care.

The instant Choi Minwoo appeared on the screen, being evacuated with a respirator over his face, everything else became meaningless.

He survived. Choi Minwoo survived.

The knowledge weighed on him.

To Go Jun, Choi Minwoo was a bastard who deserved to die. A bastard who had to die.

That was why Go Jun had laid the trap.

He had lured Jin Taekyung to Busan and used Song Cheonwoo to turn his enemies against each other, intending to leave both sides crippled.

But…

What went wrong?

Red light flickered in Go Jun's eyes. In his hand, two unpurified S-grade Magic Gems ground against each other without pause.

Crk. Crk.

What had he missed?

Crk. Crk.

He had thought the plan was perfect. Perhaps it really had been.

Its one flaw was that someone beyond perfection stood on the other side.

Jin Taekyung.

It had to be him. Behemoth's magical barrier had kept the media from learning exactly what had happened, but Go Jun had no doubt.

The bastard who had killed his Master, Lee Jungryong—a man who had seemed like a living god—and branded Go Jun with a terror he could never erase had interfered again.

Even after Go Jun had set a trap there was no escaping. Even then, again!

Crkkkk!

Instead of a roar filled with resentment, a chilling grinding sound filled the office.

Go Jun forced down his surging anger and barely managed to speak.

"Song Cheonwoo… What about Song Cheonwoo?"

When no answer came, he roared.

"I asked what happened to him!"

"…"

"Team Leader Go! Go Se-won!"

Go Se-won, the Head of Security, had watched his superior's fury in silence. He answered flatly.

"He isn't on any of the survivor or casualty lists we obtained."

"What about the Gate access records?"

"Nothing there either. We believe the Peace Guild, which effectively owns that Gate, deliberately left no traces behind."

"Of course. That makes sense. Even if Choi Minwoo is a little bastard, he's extremely careful. Isn't he?"

"…Yes."

When a secret never passed beyond the walls around it, that was both the strength and the weakness of keeping it.

Go Jun raked a hand through his hair. He picked up the whiskey in front of him, drank straight from the bottle, and muttered, "Fine. Things went to hell, but they still can't do anything about it. Song Cheonwoo can prove his alibi with the stand-in we prepared. If that gets too difficult, we make it look like he acted alone. There's no trace left in Busan, so we don't need to worry about that. Right?"

"But, Vice Guild Master, the Pyeongchang incident is too serious to pass off as Song Cheonwoo's lone crime. According to the information we obtained, Kim Hwajong—the nominal Guild Master of the Peace Guild—died, and Song Cheonwoo is unquestionably a member of Ares…"

"Listen, Team Leader Go."

A chill seized Go Se-won's entire body. His frozen figure was reflected in Go Jun's red eyes.

"Then make it less serious."

"V-Vice Guild Master."

"I don't care if it costs tens of billions[2673] or hundreds of billions[2674] of won. Throw money at the prosecutors' office. Threaten the old men sitting in the National Assembly. Grab anyone with a camera or a microphone by the collar. Isn't that your job?"

"…!"

Go Se-won's eyes trembled violently. The malice radiating from one man, along with his horrifying aura, pressed down on him.

How can someone become like this…?

It went beyond surprise. It was horrifying.

Could a person change this much in only a few months? Fall this far?

And what was this overwhelming power bearing down on him?

As he stared at Go Jun in disbelief, Song Cheonwoo's voice from several days earlier echoed in his mind.

The boundary between human and monster. That bastard Go Jun… has already become a monster.

Song was right. Go Jun—his superior—had already become a monster.

He had exploited his subordinates' near-religious loyalty and sent them to their deaths. He had deliberately caused two Monster Waves that might have left thousands, tens of thousands, perhaps even hundreds of thousands dead or injured.

All to eliminate his enemies.

A monster that has forgotten even the minimum duty a human being should possess.

Go Se-won was struggling to hide how shaken he felt when Go Jun spoke again.

"Make sure it's handled. Choi Minwoo survived, but at least we took care of Song Cheonwoo. Get us through this, and there won't be a problem."

Go Jun had regained his composure. His voice was cold.

He had failed to bring down the enemy outside Ares, but he had eliminated the one within it. That was half a victory.

[2673] Tens of billions of won is about $7–64 million or €6–58 million.

[2674] Hundreds of billions of won is about $71–640 million or €65–580 million.

Once the fake Song Cheonwoo he had put in place completed his retirement and disappeared, it would all be over.

No rumors or condemnation could bring down Ares Guild.

“Thirty years. It’s been thirty whole years. Politics, business, the prosecutors’ office, the media… They all grew under Ares’s shadow.”

Crk. Crk.

Cheon Taemin had laid the foundation, but after he lost consciousness, Lee Jungryong had built the pillars and roof.

Young politicians Ares had supported long ago had become prime ministers, ruling-party leaders, and opposition heavyweights. It was the same in business, the prosecutors’ office, and the media.

Some portion of the astronomical sums Ares Guild earned from Gates—the diamond mines of this world—had been scattered everywhere as dirty money. Those seeds had grown into a dense forest surrounding an impregnable fortress.

Go Jun was one of the people who knew that fact better than anyone.

Among the things he had inherited from his Master was a ledger packed with records of corruption and weaknesses.

“Even if everyone points fingers at us, this world itself is what protects us.”

In his impatience and anger, he had forgotten how much power he held.

And just as Go Jun’s confidence fully returned and a deep smile spread across his lips—

“You’re wrong.”

“What?”

Go Se-won looked directly at the monster before him—his superior—with an unreadable expression.

“The old politicians raised under Ares’s name, the Prosecutor General, the business and media dynasties dating back to the Japanese occupation[2675]—none of them will protect you, Vice Guild Master.”

“Team Leader Go. What are you—”

“Some of what you said is true. Ares won’t fall just because people point fingers and condemn it. But even if the whole world protects you, there’s one person it can’t stop.”

“…!”

Go Jun froze.

The thought of grabbing the Head of Security by the collar for daring to spout nonsense to his face vanished.

It was because of the name of the one person who had struck him in the mind.

Jin Taekyung.

[2675]Japan ruled Korea from 1910 to 1945.

Go Se-won read the thought in his trembling eyes and continued quietly.

“Have you forgotten who brought down the man who personally cultivated the world you’re counting on?”

“…!”

The words hit Go Jun like a blow to the back of the head. He clenched his teeth without realizing it.

Unfortunately, the bastard in front of him was not talking nonsense. Every word was true.

Master.

It was true. Lee Jungryong—Ares’s master and a man who had been no different from the king of Korea—had ultimately been killed by Jin Taekyung’s hand.

The whole world had been his, and no one in it had protected him.

Go Jun spoke through clenched teeth, his voice seething.

“Team Leader Go… You bastard.”

“I only said what someone had to say.”

“Shut up.”

“If that is your order, Vice Guild Master, I’ll obey. But please don’t dismiss what I said.”

“I told you to shut your mouth.”

Rumble!

A massive aura burst from Go Jun’s entire body like an explosion. The office shook as though an earthquake had struck.

Go Se-won’s face went pale before that overwhelming power, but his fear was nothing beside the disgust he felt.

Monster.

Go Jun saw it in his eyes and bared his teeth.

“Team Leader Go, have you gone mad? Lost your mind?”

“…”

“I only put you in the position of team leader because your abilities were at least useful. Did wearing a title that was never meant for you suddenly make the world look different?”

He gave an angry laugh and went on.

“Team Leader Go, you’re a coward and a piece of trash. You wrapped it in pretty words and called it loyal counsel, but you’re more afraid of Jin Taekyung than you are of my Master and me.”

“…That isn’t true.”

“It’s too late to deny it. Let’s admit what we both know. Yes, that bastard Jin Taekyung is strong. But how long do you think he’ll stay above me? Hmm?”

Crk. Crk!

“It’s only a matter of time. Now that I—now that I’ve decided to kill that bastard—I’ll find a way worthy of it… Damn it. Do you understand?”

Crkkkk!

His chilling voice mingled with the grinding of the Magic Gems. Go Jun glared at Go Se-won, his eyes so red they were nearly the color of blood.

He leaned his upper body forward toward the subordinate who had dared to commit an unforgivable crime. An old necklace slipped out and spun slowly in front of Go Se-won’s eyes.

“Team Leader Go. Go Se-won. You ungrateful piece of trash.”

“…”

“A year at most. Jin Taekyung… That bastard you’re so afraid of will die by my hand. Sichuan, Seoul—I don’t care where. I’ll kill him without anyone noticing, the same way Master was killed.”

“…”

“Until then, the world is on my side. No one can touch me unless I leave this fortress myself, you stupid bastard.”

The thrill of revenge mingled with his obsession with one man. Go Se-won watched the murk in his eyes for a moment, then spoke.

“A year. That’s a long time.”

“What?”

“I don’t know what method you’ve found, Vice Guild Master, but… Jin Taekyung won’t wait that long.”

“What, do you think he’s going to come charging in right now?”

“Yes.”

At the short answer, Go Jun laughed aloud. He laughed until his face twisted and the office seemed ready to fall apart from the sound. Then, suddenly, his expression sank, and he parted his lips.

“You fucking idiot. This is Ares Guild. Fall forward and you land at the Blue House[2676]; fall backward and you land at the National Assembly. Do you really think he’ll do something insane enough to turn the whole world against him?”

“I hear someone I know artificially caused a Monster Wave. Do you really think Jin Taekyung is incapable of doing something less insane than that?”

“…!”

“And, Vice Guild Master.”

Go Se-won let out a wry laugh despite himself. He remembered what he had learned from watching Jin Taekyung’s every move and investigating his past.

“Jin Taekyung is a lunatic. Didn’t you know?”

“You bas—!”

[2676]The Blue House was the traditional office and residence of South Korea’s president.

Go Jun’s eyes flew wide.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Ares Guild headquarters shook. The skyscraper of more than a hundred floors trembled.

As the roar began to fade, Go Se-won’s voice reached him.

“Dealing with that lunatic will probably be my final assignment. Thank you for everything, Vice Guild Master. If I survive, I’ll submit my resignation formally.”

Carrying both his gratitude for everything until now and his disgust toward Go Jun as a human being, Go Se-won bowed deeply. He threw open the door that had been shut tight.

Emergency sirens were waking Ares Guild.

Chapter 588

That day, the air in Korea was heavy with unease.

The Monster Waves that had erupted one after another in Busan and Pyeongchang had been successfully contained, but not without a substantial number of casualties.

People who had been going about an ordinary day were confronted with shocking news and began trembling with anxiety.

“Manager, did you see the news?”

“I did. That’s why I dropped everything and came out here.”

“I can’t focus on anything either. What if there’s really a Monster Wave near our homes or workplaces…?”

“Hey, don’t say that. You’ll jinx us. Come on, let’s have a cigarette.”

Office workers escaped their stifling workplaces and headed for cafés. Students made their way home after class. Children, unaware of what had happened, clung to their parents and begged to play longer, while their parents pulled them away just in case.

It was an uneasy afternoon, and people’s hearts were in turmoil. Eyes filled with worry and fear remained fixed on smartphones broadcasting emergency news alerts.

> — You are now looking at the collapsed Gwangan Bridge. In the nearby waters lies the corpse of Kraken, the Named Monster responsible for the Busan Monster Wave…

> — The number of casualties reported so far is approaching four thousand. Rescue and search operations are still underway. The list of confirmed casualties is available through the *Monster Disaster* app…

> — I’m at Mount Balwang in Pyeongchang, Gangwon Province. The Monster Wave has ended with the death of the Named Monster Behemoth, but the more than seven thousand people visiting the nearby condos and ski resorts remain terrified.

> — The Pyeongchang Monster Wave resulted in 371 casualties. Among the forty-five confirmed dead is Mr. Kim Hwajong, Guild Master of the Peace Guild. His death has come as a tremendous shock…

Every report was horrible and shocking. Public broadcasts, cable channels, online news articles—everywhere was in an uproar, as though someone had stirred up a hornet's nest.

People in the streets swallowed hard at the sight of Gwangan Bridge in ruins. They had no words for a city awash in blood.

Disaster. There was no other word for it.

But the media's attention did not rest solely on the damage.

No, there was one name no report on the Monster Waves could leave out.

> — Nothing like this has happened in Korea since the Great Cataclysm. Two Monster Waves struck just two hours apart and caused tremendous damage, but a flawless initial response brought the chaos under control quickly. Remarkably, one person took part in suppressing both.

> — The whereabouts of S-rank Hunter Jin Taekyung, the young hero who appeared like a comet and killed two Named Monsters in a single day, remain unknown. The Peace Guild has yet to issue an official statement…

A hero who had quelled the chaos and then vanished. Of course everyone wanted to know where he had gone.

Within minutes of the government's announcement that Jin Taekyung's whereabouts were unknown, media outlets were churning out theories.

He was dead. He was missing. He had fallen unconscious from the strain of battle.

Most of them were Third Rate media companies famous for dealing in rumors and wild gossip, but ordinary people were wondering the same thing.

Did something really happen to him?

A man with no reason to disappear had vanished without a word, without showing his face to anyone.

He was already gone when reinforcements arrived, and the Peace Guild had issued no statement.

As the news swept across Korea and spread overseas, the question grew like a snowball.

That snowball rolled and rolled, growing larger and larger, until it came to a stop amid the skyscrapers of Jongno.

Step.

No one knew when or how he had appeared.

But the people hurrying through the densely packed forest of buildings for their own reasons realized something.

The man whose profile photo filled the screens in their hands was standing before them.

Drip. Drip-drip.

He was red, and he was blue.

Every time he moved, red and blue blood soaked into the sidewalk beneath him. He was covered in the blood of humans and monsters.

At 190 centimeters[2677] tall, with a perfectly balanced build, he moved slowly forward, stepping through the blood.

"…Jin Taekyung?"

Someone's dazed voice broke the sudden silence.

The young hero had finally appeared. But no one cheered, approached him, took out a phone to photograph him, or reported the sighting to the media. They stopped and fell silent.

Perhaps it was the look in his eyes beneath his blood-soaked hair. His gaze had sunk deep.

Step. Step.

Perhaps it was because profound exhaustion seeped from every one of his footsteps.

Huff.

Perhaps it was because the white breath escaping between his split lips carried the sorrow of someone who had lost another person.

But one thing was certain. Everyone in the crowded street understood it instinctively.

They must not stand in his way.

Swish. Swoosh.

Hundreds of people parted to either side.

In place of a prophet's staff from myth, the young man carried a pure-white spear as he passed through the human sea opened just for him.

People who had watched him go with dazed eyes began to follow.

No one there knew why. They moved as though under a spell. Hundreds joined hundreds more; thousands joined thousands more.

Soon the crowd numbered in the thousands. As if hypnotized, they walked and kept walking.

The great procession had begun when one man started walking. It seemed it might go on forever, until that same man stopped.

Step.

One last step.

[2677] 190 centimeters is about 6 ft 3 in.

The young man suddenly raised his head and looked at the sky.

Five in the afternoon. A January day that had been especially cold, exhausting, and sorrowful was slowly ending in a reddish glow.

But for one person, it was not over.

It's beginning now.

Sunset light from the west flashed across a skyscraper towering above the rest. The enormous letters mounted at its top reflected in his eyes.

ARES GUILD

An impregnable fortress that could not be brought down, and a magnificent royal palace.

How many Hunters were inside? How many enemies would he have to bring down before he could face the bastard on the throne?

Hundreds? Thousands?

It didn't matter. Hundreds or thousands.

Beneath the red sky, Jin Taekyung muttered, "Well, this is perfect weather for fucking someone up."

Whoosh!

Flames the color of the sunset coiled around his arm and surged upward. The entranced crowd drew back with a collective gasp.

At that moment—

"I'm here, you fucking bastard."

Whooooooosh—BOOM!

An unprecedented force shook the skyscraper.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A massive tremor shook everything around me. The area quaked as though an earthquake had struck.

Spiderweb cracks spread across the marble covering the floor without a gap, and the splendid, valuable works of art decorating the lobby fell like a sudden shower onto the cracked marble.

Crack! Crash!

That was what I saw as soon as I entered.

The thing that had just shattered was a plaster statue of some man. I couldn't remember its name, so I asked someone nearby.

"What was that statue? I saw it in an art textbook. Rodin's *The Man Who Thought of Something*?"

"…Ah. Ahh."

A young Ares Guild member who appeared to belong to the Security Team stammered with a frozen expression.

He looked so pitiful that I changed the question.

“Then what are your personal thoughts on today’s Monster Wave?”

“P-Pardon?”

“Lucky you. Just a grunt who doesn’t know anything.”

That was what saved his life.

Whoosh!

The Finger Qi I fired cut quietly through the air and struck his acupoints.

His body went rigid and collapsed. At the same instant, a streak of light shot toward me from beyond him.

Screeeeech! Boom!

An arrow grazed my ear and smashed into the entrance door. A middle-aged man who looked like an A-rank Hunter stood with his bowstring drawn taut, aiming at me.

And his was hardly the only weapon pointed my way.

Swish, swish, swish!

Dozens of Security Team members and hundreds of other Hunters filled the lobby, watching me with tense faces. Flames and ice gathered in some hands. Others held spears, swords, or bows.

A middle-aged Hunter presumed to be the Security Team Leader spoke in a rigid voice.

“Step back, Mr. Jin.”

Step back?

I couldn’t help letting out a hollow laugh. “That’s going to be difficult.”

“Why are you doing this?”

“I have plenty of reasons. I’m not sure you’d believe them if I told you, though.”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, you…!”

I looked across the crowded lobby, my eyes hollow.

Who should I kill, and who should I spare? Which of them is directly connected to what happened today?

It took everything I had to hold back the urge to kill, rising as naturally as breathing.

Don’t forget. I’m not a monster.

If I killed everyone here today, I would become a monster. But I wanted to remain a human being until the end.

At the very least, I didn’t want innocent people dying for what their superior had done.

I thought that was the right thing to do for Kim Hwajong. For everyone.

“Let’s make this easy for everyone.”

I met hundreds of eyes and said, “Bring me Go Jun.”

“…!”

“…!”

An invisible resonance swept through the lobby and the hundreds of Hunters.

As the air tingled with it, I continued slowly.

“Right now.”

The Security Team Leader’s face stiffened. “I don’t think that will be possible.”

“Why not?”

“I have orders to stop you by any means necessary, Mr. Jin.”

“I see.”

“I don’t know what you came here for, but turn back while you still can. How many Hunters do you think are in this building? In Ares Guild House?”

“With this many in the lobby, a thousand altogether would be easy.”

“I guarantee that if you don’t leave now, everyone in this building will be after you within five minutes.”

I answered calmly.

“And I guarantee that if you don’t put down your weapons and run right now, within five minutes, every last one of you will be physically incapable of functioning normally.”

“…!”

“So get out of my sight. I don’t want to cripple people who had nothing to do with this.”

Whoooooosh!

A sudden wind swept through the lobby.

The Security Team Leader clenched his teeth beneath the powerful wave of qi pouring from my body. The polite tone he had struggled to maintain was gone, blown away by pressure beyond anything he had imagined.

“Why… Why go this far?”

“Because I’m a Hunter.”

“What?”

“Go Jun, that bastard, is a monster. Hunters don’t need a reason to kill monsters.”

Go Jun was hardly going to broadcast what he had done. Most of the people here probably had no idea what I meant.

But they would have realized one thing for certain.

Standing in my way would end badly for them.

The Security Team Leader looked at me with a complicated expression and muttered, “Fuck. What rotten luck.”

“I like your honesty. So, what’s your answer?”

The question wasn’t for him alone.

A conflicted light appeared in the eyes of the Security Team Leader and the roughly two hundred people surrounding me from every direction.

Their hands trembled around their weapons.

Then a voice boomed from the large speakers installed throughout the skyscraper.

> — Code Red. Code Red. Target: all Ares Guild members. Objective…

> — Jin Taekyung.

“…!”

“…!”

The air around us trembled.

The conflict vanished from hundreds of wide-open eyes, and countless streaks of light burst from their hands, becoming a gigantic flash that flooded every direction.

Kuwaaaaaaah!

Red, blue, and white.

I swung the dazzlingly white blade of my spear toward the enormous flash.

Whoooooosh!

Chapter 589

Countless rays of light gathered and gathered until they became a massive pillar.

Attack spells and debuffs descended from overhead. Spears, arrows, and other weapons hurled with all their might rained down around me.

But…

It was already too late to retreat. For me and for them.

Step.

I advanced toward the multicolored flashes.

As I stepped forward, I slashed White Flame diagonally downward. Scorching heat erupted from its spearhead and set everything around me ablaze.

Sssshhhhh!

Space warped. The searing blue-white hellfire forcibly dispelled every spell and devoured the weapons hurtling toward me at tremendous speed, still infused with mana.

Whoooosh!

"…!"

"…!"

Heat billowed upward, and the air shimmered. Beyond the haze, I could see hundreds of pairs of shocked eyes.

Realizing that every attack had come to nothing, the Security Team Leader drew his bowstring again. He fired ten arrows with Multi Shot and shouted, "Formation!"

Screeeeech!

While the arrows flew toward me, he moved like the wind in the opposite direction, retreating behind the tanks.

His quick judgment and precise attack were impressive, as befitted an A-rank Hunter of Ares Guild, but…

This time, you picked the wrong opponent.

I muttered the thought inwardly and thrust out my fist. The single punch driven along my smoothly rotating shoulder and arm smashed through the empty air.

Whoom! Bang!

A short, powerful straight punch.

Compressed air burst outward, whipping up a small typhoon around me. The ten arrows streaking toward me like rays of light struck it and veered off course.

Swish-swish-swish! Boom!

As the deflected arrows slammed into the lobby, I launched myself ahead of them.

I crossed the dozen or so meters[2678] between us and appeared before the Security Team Leader.

“You should’ve shot more gently. Then I would’ve made it hurt less.”

“…!”

I was far too close for him to draw his bowstring again.

Instead of answering, the Security Team Leader swung the bow in his hand. With a faint metallic click, a blade sprang from the tip of the bow and flew toward my chest.

Sssshhh!

He had probably mastered that move through thousands, perhaps tens of thousands, of repetitions.

But speed was relative. To my eyes, his attack was so slow and feeble that it made me want to yawn.

Slow enough to catch with one hand.

Clack.

The blade stopped half a handspan from me and trembled.

In a moment too brief to call an instant, I saw unmistakable shock flash across the Security Team Leader’s eyes. I tightened my grip on the middle of his bow.

Crack!

Strength beyond human limits shattered the defensive spell on the weapon, then snapped the bow made from hard monster bone.

Before the archer could cry out over the loss of his cherished weapon, my palm pressed against his chest.

Boom!

The Inner-Family Heavy Hand—striking the outside to damage the inside.

With a small explosive sound, the Security Team Leader shot backward like a cannonball.

He slammed into the lobby wall and spat blood. Screams and shouts erupted from every direction, and countless attacks poured toward me.

Swish-swish-swish! Boom-boom-boom!

Front, back, left, right. Thirty-six directions.

Watching the rays of light shoot toward me from every side, I let out a hollow laugh.

Three jiazi[2679] of Scorching Yang Qi rose from my dantian, became a fire dragon, and entered my spear.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, First Form: Fire Dragon’s Single Tail.

Fwoosh! Whoooosh!

[2678] A dozen or so meters is roughly 12 m, or about 39 ft.

[2679] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi represents 180 years of accumulated power.

I turned smoothly and swung the spear. Flames surged upward in a whirl, blocking and burning everything in their path.

I stepped forward without hesitation. The marble beneath my foot crumbled like sand.

Sssshhh!

A fierce wind brushed past my ears. Someone's desperate shout mingled with it.

"Stop him—!"

Boom!

The roar swallowed the rest of the shout. Dozens of tanks who had frozen in place to block my path were flung away, their screams filling the gap.

"Guh!"

"Graaaah!"

Bodies as hard as steel. Combat experience gained over hundreds of raids. None of it helped them now.

Overwhelming strength was enough to crush anything in its way.

Yet the Hunters in the lobby, who had turned against me after wavering, kept coming.

Their weapons caught the light of a half-severed chandelier and flashed as they closed in from every direction.

Pap-pap-pap!

Cheek, neck, armpit, waist, calf…

I saw and felt it all.

It wasn't only my body that had surpassed human limits.

Before my brain could pass along what my sharpened senses told it, I was already moving.

Crack!

I caught a swordsman's arm beneath my armpit and broke it.

Thud!

I drove my elbow into another Hunter's solar plexus and knocked him down.

Tap—swish-swish-swish!

I snatched an arrow flying toward my throat and flung it back the way it had come.

As I turned toward the enemies closing in from all sides, short screams pierced my ears.

"Gah!"

"Ugh!"

It wasn't happening in just one spot. Screams rang out across the lobby.

Every time I dodged a weapon, threw a punch or a kick, or swung the shaft of my spear, someone screamed and collapsed or flew away like a cannonball.

“Don’t hesitate! Fight!”

Boom! Whoooooom!

“Hit him all at once!”

Swish-swish-swish!

Two hundred against one.

No—a raid launched against a single human being. But I wasn’t the one being driven back. They were.

Magic? Weapons?

Nothing could touch me. I plunged deep into their formation and tore through it, wrecking it from within—without killing them.

I struck enough fear into them to keep them from charging at me again before today’s battle was over.

Crack-crack-crack!

“Graaaah!”

Boom!

Before one person’s scream had even ended, three people fell. By the time three screams rang out, five had collapsed.

They were sheep, and I was a great tiger.

With one difference: I had the patience to hold back from slaughtering them.

I’m not a monster. I’m not a monster.

I had to repeat it endlessly in my mind to calm the rage swelling inside me to the point of bursting.

Those who crossed to the other side of the river never returned. Jopil hadn’t. Neither had the forces of Dark Heaven, or Go Jun, who had stepped into the realm of monsters for the sake of his goal.

But I was a Hunter. A martial artist of Murim.

I suddenly remembered something a certain person had once told me—a person who had gone from being the greatest assassin of all time to the greatest physician under heaven.

The weak kill, but the truly strong can save lives instead. It means they can prevent innocent deaths, no matter the circumstances.

If I had been less powerful than I was now—if I had been both weak and evil—they would all have died.

But I was human, not a monster. And I had the strength to save them.

“Everyone… move aside.”

Boom!

The palm force I thrust out swept away dozens of people and sent them flying.

Maybe it was the battle that had gone on for hours without a break. Maybe it was the aftermath of One Annihilation. I was exhausted beyond measure.

Yet everything seemed slow and clear. Their movements. Their expressions. I caught every detail.

I could see the mages' staffs shining between the fragments of shattered Tower Shields.

Vrrrrrrm!

The Magic Gems embedded in the heads of the staffs vibrated faintly and gave off a dazzling glow.

But before their spells could take shape, I was already among the twenty or so mages.

"Ma—Magic Shi—!"

Too late.

Swish—thump!

A mage trying to cast a defensive spell went rigid and fell.

He wasn't the only one. Ten fingers sent out ten streams of Finger Qi. The instant they brushed the mages' acupoints, the mages crumpled like a collapsing wall.

But this was Ares Guild headquarters, a place said to recruit only the best. High-ranking Hunters—whom ordinary Hunters rarely even encountered—were as plentiful as grains of sand here.

"Binding!"

Shrrrriiiip!

Between the broken marble, vines burst from the wall where an unknown oil painting had once hung and wrapped around my ankles like whips.

Crack!

A magical rope appeared out of thin air and bound my wrists with tremendous force.

Was he the Team Leader in charge of the mages? An A-rank mage I had once seen on television fixed me with a look full of killing intent.

"Kill him."

At that moment—

Swish!

The air above my head rippled. A pale shadow, faint as mist, dropped toward the crown of my head.

Realizing that the sound cutting through the air came from a short sword, I let out a hollow laugh inwardly.

Look at these bastards.

I realized two things.

First, Code Red meant it didn't matter whether the target lived or died. Second, I had no reason to go easy on the ones who were actually trying to kill me.

In that case…

I welcomed it.

Boom!

The instant a short flame erupted, the assassin was flung away with his limbs twisted, unable even to scream amid the explosive roar.

The A-rank mage stared wide-eyed as I burned through every rope and vine, turning the assassin's short sword over in my hand.

"What are you doing? Why aren't you using Magic?"

"I-Ice Blo—!"

Crash! Thunk!

The short sword streaked forward like a ray of light, shattered the Magic Gem in his staff, and buried itself deep in his abdomen. The backflow of mana must have made the pain unbearable.

I struck the chest of the mage, who was screaming loudly enough to shake the lobby.

Boom!

The Inner-Family Heavy Hand was fatal to anyone, but it possessed even greater destructive power against those who directly handled mana, such as mages and healers.

Even if this one survived, he was in no shape to call himself a mage again. His eyes rolled back, and he collapsed.

I stared calmly at the mage, unconscious with an irrecoverable injury, and suddenly opened my mouth.

"Anyone else want to retire while we're at it?"

"…!"

"If not, go to sleep."

Swish-swish-swish! Thump!

Another volley of Finger Qi flew out. The remaining mages dropped without a fight, and silence fell over the lobby.

The clock straight ahead showed that only three minutes had passed since the battle began. Of the roughly two hundred Hunters, fewer than one in ten were still on their feet.

Wheeeeeeeeeeng!

Beneath the unending wail of the alarm, the scene was horrific.

Tanks were embedded in the walls. Damage dealers gasped in pain. Mages lay stiff, staring at the ceiling.

And there I stood, looking down at them all.

My voice came out through parted lips, hoarse and cracked.

“Don’t stand in my way again. There won’t be a second time.”

“…!”

“…!”

Those still standing and those on the floor alike stared at me with trembling eyes.

They must have understood by now. They weren’t alive because they had been lucky.

Step.

With the alarm blaring over the silent crowd, I walked slowly to the center of the lobby.

Then I channeled three jiazi[2680] of internal energy, kicked off the floor, and shot upward.

Screeeeech!

The lobby ceiling rushed toward me with the fierce wind. At the same time, blue-white flames flickered over my clenched fist.

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist burst forth, burning through the air.

Kuwaaaaaang!

[2680] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi represents 180 years of accumulated power.

Chapter 590

Everything began and ended in an instant.

Fwoosh.

The overwhelming heat of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist lived up to its name, surging upward in blue-white flames.

Kuwaaaaaang!

The tremendous roar that erupted the next moment swallowed every other sound.

Layer after layer of powerful defensive Magic gave way. Even ceilings made of exceptionally durable magical materials collapsed and melted under the extreme heat.

Boom! Boom! KABOOM!

One, three, five. Ten.

Each time a ceiling vanished, another appeared to block my path.

But I surged upward as a pillar of fire, smashing, piercing, and melting everything that stood in my way.

Boom. Crack.

How high had I climbed? How many ceilings had I broken through?

When I finally came to a stop, beyond the wavering flames…

“Fire!”

There were people waiting for me—no, enemies who had finished making every possible preparation.

Screeeeech!

As if they had been waiting for this moment alone, the enemies fired arrows, Magic, and everything else at once.

And at the moment countless rays of light shot toward me, I muttered a command in my mind that no one could hear.

Inventory. Store.

Swish.

The cool spear shaft vanished from my grip. I drew the lingering flames into both hands and thrust out my palms.

Flame Divine Palm.

Fwoosh. Whoooooosh!

Flame Divine Palm at eight-tenths mastery. A fire dragon burst from both palms and writhed through the air.

Terrible heat swept through the wide corridor stretching out on either side. Magic, arrows, and even people were caught in it.

“Graaaaaaaaaah!”

“Healer! Healeeer!”

When the flames died down, screams and a foul stench remained. The smell of cooking flesh hung over the corridor, and cries of pain rose from every direction.

If I had used my full strength, more than half of them would have burned to death without a scream.

“H-How could this…?”

I turned toward the voice.

At the end of the corridor, a dozen or so healers stood with their mouths open, staring at the scene before them.

“What are you doing? Get your asses over here and save your comrades.”

At my flat remark, a middle-aged woman who looked like a Team Leader bit her lip.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, why on earth are you…?”

“Because there’s something I absolutely have to do. And because you people got in my way.”

“I don’t know what your circumstances are, but still… This is too much, isn’t it?”

Her eyes were full of fear and anger. Looking at her, I felt like the worst bastard in the world. Maybe that was why a hollow laugh escaped me.

The Ares Guild emblems sewn onto their clothes irritated me. So did the nerve of them.

That was why I stopped instead of walking away.

“Too far? Fuck, you’re the ones who went too far.”

“W-What?”

“I don’t think people who came swarming over to kill me at the words *Code Red* get to say that.”

“…!”

“I said all I needed was to meet one person. I even tried to avoid a fight with people who had nothing to do with this. But you attacked first, and you’re the ones who went down.”

I understood that they had no direct connection to Kim Hwajong’s death. How could the hands and feet know what the head had planned?

But receiving an order didn’t erase what they had done. They had assembled to kill a person because someone told them to.

“Why are you doing this? I don’t know what your circumstances are, but…”

My quiet voice carried over the low groans and echoed through the blackened corridor.

“Don’t spout bullshit. You should’ve thought about it before asking. Why did that bastard Jin Taekyung suddenly start acting like this? Why did a guy everyone praised for saving people and killing monsters come to our Guild and cause a

scene, demanding that we bring out Go Jun? And why was an order given to kill him?"

These days, people called me a hero.

To give them the conclusion first: I wasn't. I didn't have some noble spirit of self-sacrifice. I cared about money, and I'd rather live for my own people than for strangers I'd never met.

But… I thought I'd lived without shame.

Since gaining power far beyond anything I deserved, I believed I'd used it for other people whenever I could.

I had always questioned myself—what kind of person I was, whether the choices I made were right.

"So why? Why? Why?"

I kept throwing out those empty questions. The vacant faces in my view disgusted and repulsed me.

"When you're told to kill someone, why do you come here without even questioning the order?"

No one answered. I knew the answer anyway.

Because they were nothing more than fingernails—not even Go Jun's hands and feet. Because they were dogs living off the food Go Jun and Ares Guild gave them.

Do the job, and they could gain more wealth and status. That was why they had stood in my way, just as they always had.

"Do you even have any idea what that bastard Go Jun has done? What if the Monster Waves in Busan and Pyeongchang were artificially caused by him?"

The moment I finished speaking, shouts erupted from every direction.

"Bullshit!"

"That's impossible!"

Right. I'd expected that. It was why I'd come all the way here.

I looked at their disbelieving faces and let out a laugh.

It was fascinating. They remained silent about why a man called a hero had invaded Ares Guild, yet when it came to other matters, they immediately denied everything.

"What did your bosses promise you for taking me down? A fast track to the top of the Guild? Enough money to keep your families fed for generations?"

"…!"

"And please, spare me the bullshit about needing money to raise your kids or support your widowed mother. None of you are going hungry."

Everyone here had made it. Whether they'd wanted to or not, they'd Awakened one day and shown enough talent to join Ares Guild.

I didn’t begrudge them the wealth or status that came with it. I’d once dreamed of having those things myself.

What disgusted me was that they’d chosen to do wrong to get even more, then found ways to justify it.

When each person stayed silent, the whole group learned to do the same. That was how they had become the defenders of Ares, an impregnable fortress.

“So.”

I took a deep breath. Exhaustion, anger, disgust—everything churned together in my chest.

“Stop spouting this fucking nonsense and lie down. Suck down your potions and get healed while you think about it. *Today is my second birthday.* Think of it that way.”

“…”

“…”

The corridor fell quiet. Even the groans I’d been hearing all around me stopped.

Those still standing and those lying on the ground alike either closed their eyes or firmly shut their mouths.

I ignored their trembling gazes and started walking. I didn’t forget a final goodbye.

“Morons.”

Whether my words had gotten through to them or they still thought like hunting dogs, I didn’t care. I had only one target.

And to reach the fucker who still hadn’t shown himself, I had plenty more obstacles to break through.

Step.

My foot came down on neatly trimmed grass.

The world was still in the middle of a bitterly cold winter, but after passing through the corridor, the garden spread out at its center was a lush spring.

I had no idea what floor I was on. Hundreds of flowers bloomed around me, and a smaller number of enemies waited among them.

“Quite a turnout, you fuckers.”

Swish!

My greeting was answered by an arrow packed with mana.

It was aimed straight at my eye. The archer was a nasty bastard, and with that much mana in the arrow, he was plainly trying to kill me.

In that case, returning the favor was only fair. At least, that was how I did things.

Clack. Swish!

I caught the arrow and hurled it back in the same motion.

The arrowhead flashed as it returned to its owner twice as fast and twice as powerfully as when it had first been fired.

Kang!

A white sword blade shuddered with a sharp metallic ring.

A middle-aged man in his fifties stared at me with deeply sunken eyes. He had deflected the arrow with an enormous greatsword.

His seasoned bearing and aura reminded me of a Murim martial artist nearing the far end of Peak.

“You’re as impatient as I heard, junior.”

“It’s nice to meet you, Senior.”

With all the courtesy of a junior, I cracked my knuckles.

Crack.

The joints, stiff with dried blood, made a sound like bones shifting out of place.

“If you step aside now, I’ll pass through quietly. Except for the bastard who fired that arrow.”

Slap!

The archer’s head snapped to one side.

The middle-aged man slapped the archer on his right across the face with lightning speed, then looked at me.

“He’s young and foolish. I ask you to show him mercy.”

“That wasn’t a mistake. I’ll have to break his wrist.”

“He should be grateful to get off with that. What matters is that he survives.”

What was with this guy?

He was different from the Ares Guild members I’d faced so far. As I watched him, the middle-aged man went on calmly.

“I appreciate your offer, but I’m afraid I have to refuse. I may not look it, but I’m a Guild executive. I have to hang on to your trouser leg, if nothing else.”

“That won’t end well for you.”

“What can I do? I’m a hunting dog too, in the end. I can guess how this will turn out, but I’d appreciate it if you went easy on me.”

What was it about his attitude?

I silently studied the middle-aged man. Then I suddenly arrived at a conclusion and opened my mouth.

“Song Cheonwoo. No—you’re with Director Song’s faction.”

His eyes widened. I’d guessed right.

Which meant I had no reason to fight them.

Song Cheonwoo had led his own faction within Ares Guild and openly opposed Go Jun. The middle-aged man in front of me must have shared his convictions.

“You… knew?”

“I heard it from someone close to him. We don’t need to fight. Step aside.”

The middle-aged man let out a hollow laugh.

“The enemy of my enemy is my ally?”

“At least right now, I don’t want to waste my strength or my time.”

Step.

As I started forward again, he raised his greatsword at an angle.

He was ready to attack. His troubled voice reached me.

“Stop. I don’t want to do this either, but I have no choice.”

I answered without stopping.

“If you don’t want to, why are you here? Because you’re a hunting dog who can’t do anything but obey orders?”

“…!”

“If you’re afraid of Go Jun, say you’re afraid. Don’t dress it up as having no choice.”

It wasn’t only the middle-aged man. Everyone looking at me had trembling eyes.

I continued forward. The more than a hundred people ahead of me backed away.

The middle-aged man’s composure began to crack.

“The tide has already turned. I heard Director Song returned to the United Kingdom this morning. What do you think that means? I had to find a way to survive. Even if it meant acting like a hunting dog.”

Song Cheonwoo had gone to the United Kingdom this morning? Obviously a lie.

Certain that Go Jun had put forward a stand-in, I let out a quiet snort of laughter.

“What if that hunting dog’s master dies today?”

“…!”

Every eye widened.

I reached into empty air and summoned White Flame from my Inventory. Its blade swept down diagonally.

Swish!

A single line cut through the air.

Everyone caught their breath. But there was no spray of blood, no death.

The Force that shot from the white spearhead had cut something other than a person.

Slice. Crash!

At the center of the garden stood an ornate fountain. The enormous stone statue planted atop it broke apart and collapsed.

The remains of a statue modeled after a man who was already dead crushed the flowers beneath it.

Its head, severed from the body, rolled and rolled until it reached my feet.

The statue was so lifelike I had no trouble recognizing its face.

Lee Jungryong.

That was right.

Today, the magnificent palace built by an ambitious warlord who had wanted everything would fall.

Along with the Disciple who had become a monster.

I tossed a few words at the stunned crowd.

“You have two choices. Put down your weapons and clear a path, or cover my back.”

“…!”

Chapter 591

Beep. Beep. Beep.

The ringing went on for a long time before abruptly cutting off.

Instead of the voice he had been waiting for, a familiar yet still strangely unfamiliar woman's voice came through the phone.

"Your call cannot be connected. After the beep, you will be directed to voicemail…"

Normally, he would have hung up. No, he would never have called in the first place.

But the middle-aged man had a vague sense that the words he was about to record might be the last he ever left his family.

Beeeeeeep.

The tone sounded, but he couldn't bring himself to speak.

What could he say to his wife, who was carrying their second child, and their child, who had only just turned four?

And just as the middle-aged man—Go Se-won—was finally about to speak after much thought…

Rumble…

A faint vibration shook the entire building. At the same time, the voice of a security-team member waiting outside seeped through the crack in the door.

"Team Leader, I think you need to come out."

"…"

"Team Leader?"

"Wait. I'm coming."

Go Se-won ended the call.

Maybe it's a sign. Someone telling me to stay alive and see my family again.

And if it isn't…

Then I suppose I don't even deserve to leave them my last words.

Go Se-won muttered bitterly to himself before opening the door. A security-team member with a hard, expressionless, familiar face was waiting for him.

"I'm sorry. It's just that outside—"

"I know. Let's go."

Go Se-won cut him off calmly and crossed the unlit corridor.

Ahead lay a vast circular hall befitting the top floor, with roughly a hundred fully armed elite Guild members inside.

And filling the hall was a holographic image.

BOOM!

A flash burst across it with a deafening explosion.

Fwooooooosh!

Rays of light surged from two opposing formations and shot toward each other.

“Graaaaaah!”

“Tanks! Reform the line!”

Screams and shouts came from every direction. Hundreds of Hunters clashed in a scene so vivid it might have been unfolding right before him.

Only minutes ago, they had belonged to the same Guild. Now they fought as enemies.

That’s…

Go Se-won watched the fierce battle in the hologram, his gaze darkening.

He recognized the faces fighting at the front: Guild executives from Song Cheonwoo’s faction.

Anti-Ares… So it’s come to this.

A body without a head was bound to fall.

But not this time. Song Cheonwoo, its head, had been removed, only for a stronger one to grow in his place. That was how a body sentenced to death had risen again.

In the hologram, a young man walked forward drenched in human and monster blood. He had become their new rallying point.

“A monster…”

Someone watching muttered the word like a groan.

At that moment, blue-white hellfire blazed around the young man—Jin Taekyung.

Fwoosh! KABOOOOOM!

A streak of flame tore through the space, scorching everything around it.

Huge Tower Shields shattered. Dozens of tanks who had held firm as an iron wall were sent flying at once, and the balance that had held until then collapsed.

“Graaaaaah!”

“Now! Attack!”

Amid spraying blood and falling bodies, the flame that had incapacitated an entire raid team in one blow kept shooting forward.

Screeeeeech!

It was an inextinguishable flame, an unstoppable meteor.

Ceilings said to withstand bombardment collapsed like dominoes, and the forces waiting on each floor fell like bundles of straw.

Whenever the hologram wavered, unable to keep pace with the flame, Jin Taekyung was already on another floor, bringing down new enemies.

“St-Stop him…!”

KABOOOOOM!

Nothing could stand against that overwhelming power. Jin Taekyung had become a streak of flame, shooting onward without pause.

As the troops stationed floor by floor crumbled, the executives in Song Cheonwoo's faction—still wavering, still unable to decide—finally turned their weapons on their former allies.

"W-we're on the eighty-fifth floor! Managing Director Kim Jong-pil and Team Thirteen have betrayed us. Gah!"

"Headquarters, respond! There's a revolt on the ninety-seventh floor…!"

Fwoosh! Boom!

A strong current became a wave. A rolling snowball grew larger.

That was what was happening now. The fire that had been racing in one direction had spread on all sides.

And Go Se-won knew Jin Taekyung's flame would not go out until his anger subsided—until it swallowed one man whole.

"The target has broken through the hundredth floor!"

"Fighting has broken out on twelve floors at once! Hostile elements have joined the target and are engaging our forces!"

"The target is moving alone! He's on the 103rd floor! No—the 104th!"

Urgent reports flew from every direction. The executives who had seemed so relaxed when first summoned to the top floor now looked anxious.

"H-hey, Team Leader Go. May I ask you something?"

Go Se-won answered without looking away from the hologram.

"Go ahead, Executive Director Choi."

"I've been wondering for a while…"

The half-gray-haired man swallowed. Then he voiced the question on everyone's mind.

"Where… where on earth is the Vice Guild Master?"

Go Se-won glanced around. Among the hundred or so people in the hall, the one man who should have been fighting ahead of them all was nowhere to be seen.

Yet despite the bleak situation, Go Se-won felt lighter.

Yes. This should be enough.

When told to bite, he bit. When told to bark, he barked.

He had been one of the countless war orphans left by the Great Cataclysm. He had risen to his present position by living as a faithful hunting dog.

The irony was that knowing it made him sick with himself.

With this, I've repaid everything I owed you. Whether I live or die, it has nothing to do with you anymore.

Go Se-won muttered those words in his heart toward the person who still refused to appear, then firmly drew his sword.

Shing.

His calm voice cut through the sharp sound.

“The Vice Guild Master… He won’t be coming.”

“W-what did you say?”

“So fight if you want to live. You’ve eaten far too much from his hand to spit it back out now.”

Everyone here was a hunting dog. They had taken the food their master gave them and lived well on it. They had no choice left.

I’m no different.

A humorless laugh escaped Go Se-won. The executives stared at him.

Then a cry rang through the enormous hall.

“The 119th floor! The target has broken through the 119th floor!”

“…!”

“…!”

No one had trouble understanding what that meant. They all knew the building they came to work in every day had 120 floors.

He’s coming.

There was no avoiding the fight.

Clad in full armor, a sword in one hand and a spear in the other, Go Se-won spoke with a heavy heart.

“Formation. Prepare for battle.”

His quiet command reached the hundred Hunters around him.

Rumble! KABOOM!

With a deafening roar accompanied by a tremendous vibration, one of the world’s most famous skyscrapers shook.

An uninvited guest had set foot on the top floor of an impregnable fortress no one had ever been able—or dared—to challenge.

Step.

A lone figure appeared through the rising dust.

Every hair on Go Se-won’s body seemed to stand on end. He hurled his spear with all his strength.

Whoosh! Screeeeeech!

Slice!

The spear hurtling toward me split apart, along with the cloud of dust.

Through the clear path White Flame had cut, I saw a middle-aged man who looked strangely familiar.

Where have I seen him?

The answer came almost at once.

At Lee Jungryong's national funeral, a new Head of Security had stood beside Go Jun like a shadow. This was him.

The name I had heard in passing back then was probably…

"Go Se-won."

His eyes trembled faintly when I said it.

Maybe he was surprised I knew his name. Maybe it was how easily I'd dealt with his spear.

Either way, I'd finally found someone who might give me a proper answer. I asked the question I'd repeated dozens of times since entering the lobby.

"Go Jun. Where is he?"

Before I'd finished speaking, a flash shot from Go Se-won's hand.

Whoosh! KABOOM!

A throwing spear missed me by a hair and buried itself in the floor, leaving a small crater.

It was a signal.

Fwish-fwish-fwish!

Go Se-won wasn't the only one waiting on the top floor. Roughly a hundred Ares Guild members filled the hall, every one of them worthy of being called a high-ranking Hunter. They attacked together.

Fwoosh!

A vast surge of energy shook the hall, filling it with blue, red, and brilliant light.

Their attacks were stronger and their barrage denser than anything I'd faced on the way up. I stepped forward alone.

Step.

My foot struck the floor, charged with internal energy, and flames rose to heat the air.

Flamefire Path.

Fwoosh! Screeeeeech!

One step was enough. I erased more than ten meters[2681] of distance and struck at the air with my palm.

Arrows melted before the blue-white hellfire. Every spell flying toward me came apart.

BOOM!

Water, earth, wind, flame.

[2681] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

The intense heat of Scorching Yang Qi ignored even elemental affinities. As attack spells made from all four elements burst outward, the tanks at the front swiftly raised their Tower Shields.

KABOOM!

Despite the considerable impact, the Tower Shields didn't waver an inch. They blocked the aftermath of the Magic without suffering the slightest damage, then tilted diagonally.

At the same moment, twenty figures sprang up, using the wall of steel as a foothold.

Pat-pat-pat!

I understood at once. Everyone gathered here was among Ares Guild's elite. But the ones coming at me now were in another class.

Killing intent.

Their movements were spare and swift. Their calm, impassive eyes had the look of practiced killers.

More than twenty weapons stabbed and slashed at the speed of light, flashing brightly.

Screeeeeech!

As they came at me from every angle, I couldn't hold back a short laugh.

"What a load of bullshit. You fucking morons."

"…!"

In the slowed world, I saw shock spread across their blank faces.

But it was too late to turn back. For them and for me.

Slice!

Blue-white Force extended from White Flame's spearhead. The incoming weapons lost their strength, and five bodies split in two.

Having turned five bodies into ten with one strike, I drove my fist into empty air.

BOOM!

Compressed air wasn't the only thing that burst.

A stealthily approaching assassin toppled over, headless. By then, the chain sickle in his hand was already moving at my will.

Whoosh! Thud!

Wielded by Seizing an Object Through Empty Space, it buried itself in another man's neck.

His once-calm eyes flew wide. As he began to fall, I planted my palm against his chest.

BOOM!

The force of my Flame Divine Palm wasn't meant to finish him off. He was already dead.

It struck the enemy behind him, who had been about to use his comrade's body as a shield while thrusting his spear.

"Graaaaaah!"

Blood burst from the man's seven apertures[2682].

Before the man whose heart meridians had been severed throughout his body could even lower his head, I was already moving toward another enemy.

Crack!

My fist crushed a head.

Fwish! Thud-thud!

Finger Qi shot through another enemy's neck and chest. He dropped his weapon and pressed a hand to the blood gushing from his throat. It wasn't enough.

"Ghk. Guh…"

The light faded rapidly from his eyes. I watched the last of them collapse, my gaze cold.

You brought this on yourselves.

On another day, I might have let them live. But not today. Not now.

As when the Black Hunters had attacked Uncle Kkeokjeong, I had no intention of stopping. I couldn't stop.

I have to show them here. Make sure this never happens again.

I had been a Hunter long before I became a martial artist.

I had also been a modern man born in the twenty-first century, someone who had lived in a civilized society where reason and the law existed. That was why I hadn't been able to eliminate Go Jun in Sichuan.

Unlike Lee Jungryong, whom I had been able to eliminate amid chaos and destruction, Go Jun had been protected by a fence built from the two-syllable Korean term for the rule of law.

But now none of that mattered.

My choice had allowed Go Jun to live. He had crossed a river he could never cross back. And I—no, all of us—had lost Kim Hwajong.

I would never again see the half-gray-haired old butler who had always spoken to me with a polite, gentle smile.

That was why I had come here. Why I had torn down the fence called the rule of law and made myself an outlaw.

Splash.

My blood-soaked footsteps sounded unnaturally loud.

A suffocating silence had settled over the vast hall. Everyone stood frozen by the slaughter they had witnessed.

[2682] The seven apertures are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

But the face I wanted wasn't among them. Neither was the one man who could tell me where to find him.

Go Se-won.

I turned my head to look for Go Jun's right hand.

A faint, stealthy sound cut through the air.

Whoosh!

I turned around and slammed my hands together as though in prayer.

KABOOM!

The sharp sword blade caught between them stopped just above my forehead.

Its owner, Go Se-won, spoke calmly.

"Looking for me?"

"Yeah."

I pressed my palms together harder. The Sword Energy—or rather, Aura—formed from powerful mana yielded to my blue-white Force.

Unable to withstand my immense internal energy, the sword glowed red and began to melt.

Drip, drip. Hiss!

As the molten steel struck the floor, I thrust out a hand blazing with heat.

BOOM!

One palm strike was enough. Layer upon layer of defensive Magic shattered, and Go Se-won's armor broke apart.

But the blow that shook him to the core didn't bring him down. He swallowed the blood rising in his throat and reached for my shoulder with his gauntlet.

He tried to, anyway.

Tap-tap-tap! BOOM!

A flowing grappling technique followed seamlessly. Another burst of heat drove Go Se-won back, and he thrust out his hand.

Fwish!

A blade sprang from between the plates of his gauntlet and grazed my chin. I felt a sting, caught his wrist, and twisted.

Crack! KRAK!

My grip crushed the gauntlet. Flesh tore, exposing white bone.

The pain must have been worse than he'd imagined, but Go Se-won didn't scream. Pale-faced, he asked flatly,

"Is that it?"

"No. Not yet."

I caught his other arm.

KRAK!

He sucked in a breath.

This time the pain broke through his composure. Blood ran between his lips, and his voice shook.

“Take it easy… and finish it.”

“That’s the plan. After I hear where that bastard Go Jun is.”

“What if the confidentiality clause in my employment contract says I can’t?”

I gripped his collarbone.

“Then it definitely won’t end with just taking it easy.”

Go Se-won gave a weak laugh.

“You searched everywhere and still couldn’t find him. Of course you couldn’t.”

Unfortunately, he was right. I’d fought my way through an endless pack of hunting dogs and wrecked the inside of the building, but Go Jun had never appeared.

If there was one thing I had gained from all the information I had collected so far, it was the identity of the secret area where he was staying.

“Area A. I think you know where it is.”

Cough.

Go Se-won spat blood.

“I picked a bad day. I was planning to hand in my resignation soon.”

“Enough talking. Tell me.”

“That’s easy. But I have a condition.”

“T-Team Leader Go. You’re not going to tell that crazy bastard—!”

There was always someone who couldn’t read the room. The nameless executive who stepped forward soon went quiet, though. Few people could go on talking after taking Finger Qi to the throat.

“A condition?” I asked.

“Yes.”

What he said next caught even me off guard.

“…You want me to kill you?”

Go Se-won gave a small nod. Even as pain wracked his body, his eyes remained calm, reflecting my face.

“It’s too late to go back to how things were. Do it cleanly. Right here. That’s all.”

“…”

“I think you understand.”

Breathing heavily, Go Se-won raised a trembling finger and pointed somewhere.

When I finally learned where Area A was, I stopped short.

Empty air?

It was hard to make sense of at first, but the world called things like this Magic. Besides, I’d experienced things far stranger and more dangerous than Magic.

Where?

I stared into the empty air. After a moment, an unfamiliar sensation stirred in my exhausted body.

What's this?

I couldn't see it. But I could feel another space there, surrounded by an immense, carefully concealed energy.

It was hidden so perfectly that it could only be detected by someone who recognized its existence.

Go Se-won had kept his end of the bargain. His lips, turning blue, began to move.

"Now kill—"

Bzzzz.

A vibration cut him off.

A smartphone slipped from the trouser pocket of the suit exposed beneath his broken armor and rolled across the floor.

Tap. Bzzzz.

A family photo lit up its cracked screen beneath the caller's name: **Wife**.

A young child and his wife smiled brightly. Beside them stood Go Se-won, his expression stiff.

"…"

For a moment, neither of us spoke. I looked from the photo on the cracked screen to the cracks showing in his expression.

I remembered his request to be killed. The calm way he'd said it was too late to go back.

"Let me ask you something."

"…?"

"Why is today your last day at work?"

Go Se-won hesitated, then answered with a sigh.

"Turns out the job doesn't suit me. Especially… my boss is a fucking asshole."

"Yeah. Got it."

Did Go Se-won know that answer had decided his fate?

I quietly drew up my internal energy.

Not toward my fist.

Toward my legs.

"You—"

KABOOM!

The rest of his words vanished beneath the roar.

I was already soaring into the empty air high above. Fierce wind rushed past me. I felt the strange buoyancy of being seized by invisible hands, and the unknown space that refused entry to anyone without permission.

But I was an outlaw. I didn’t need permission.

There.

Everything had a flow.

I took a deep breath and closed my eyes. Blue-white Force burst from the spearhead in my hand and tore through the empty air.

Swooooooosh!

Chapter 592

Whoooosh.

Red mist rose with his exhaled breath.

It was a long, slow breath—so long and slow that one might mistake him for not breathing at all. It was also a secret technique he had learned from his Master long ago.

“I’ve been watching you all this time.”

“M-Me?”

Nearly thirty years had passed, but Go Jun had never forgotten that day. It was the day he first found a dream.

He had lost his parents, been abandoned by his relatives, and drifted from one orphanage to another.

“The other children you live with are talented, too. But you’re different. You’re very special.”

The Great Cataclysm had left behind more than death and peace. It had created an enormous number of war orphans, and Go Jun was one of them.

Just one of countless war orphans. If he had remained ordinary, he would have been raised like a chicken confined to a poultry farm, then turned loose on society.

But meeting his Master, Lee Jungryong, had made him someone special.

That was the greatest reason he had stayed alone in Area A after everyone else had disappeared, waiting for the person who would soon come crashing in.

He could not flee his Master’s enemy from the place where his Master had once lived.

“…Jin Taekyung.”

Go Jun’s voice was chilling. His tightly shut eyes slowly opened, and he drew the red glow back into them. Then he instinctively reached for his neck.

Clink.

His fingers touched cold metal.

He did not even know who had originally owned this cheap necklace. Yet it had become the keepsake his Master had left him, and his most precious possession, for one reason alone: it was the only thing that had kept its shape when everything else in that place turned to ash.

Are you watching, Master?

Go Jun clenched his fist. Red qi shimmered like heat haze over the skin stretched taut across his prominent veins.

Only two months ago, Jin Taekyung had trampled him mercilessly. But things were different now.

Hatred greater than his fear, and the power he had newly acquired, had allowed Go Jun to overcome it.

I'll kill him. Today. With my own hands.

Was it his imagination? Or a coincidence?

At that very moment, the black jewel set into the necklace gave off a strange light.

Rumble!

A tremendous vibration shook the space.

This was a place where anyone who had not been granted permission could not even become aware of its existence. Now, at last, it had allowed someone to intrude.

Countless spells and barriers that had never once been broken since their creation were collapsing even now.

"He's here."

Go Jun muttered quietly, released his cross-legged position, and slowly rose to his feet. Top-grade magic armor surged up around his body, wrapping around him according to his will.

Clatter-clatter-clatter!

The transformation began and ended in an instant.

By the time Go Jun stood firmly on both feet in blackened full-body armor, blue-white flames were flickering like will-o'-the-wisps at the end of the unlit corridor.

No. It was the glow in someone's eyes.

"Jin Taekyung…!"

He spat the three syllables with hatred. The man whose name he had called answered willingly.

"Yeah. So you were here."

Unlike the burning glow in his eyes, his voice was cold.

But Go Jun could clearly feel it—the ember hidden inside that voice. The fuse that had refused to burn while waiting for this one moment.

And then—

"Thanks."

Fwoosh.

At last, the flame caught. A voice boiling like lava heated the dark corridor.

"For staying here all this time."

An overwhelming energy pressed down on the space.

Rrrrmmble!

There would be no more waiting.

As the world shook, two figures became streaks of light and shot across the corridor toward each other.

The instant the blue and red streaks met—

Whoom, KABOOM!

A blinding flash and a deafening roar that seemed to split the sky erupted, coloring the entire area.

The most important thing when facing an enemy was composure. When reason grew clouded, the mind became unsettled. When the mind became unsettled, the hands and feet lost their coordination.

Maintaining composure was the surest way to win.

That rule held true in both the modern world and Murim, and I had always followed it.

But…

"Jin Taekyung."

The moment I heard the hatred in his voice and saw that fucking face clearly beyond the dark corridor, I realized something.

Composure was no shield against anger reason could not contain.

Once that fire caught, there was no controlling it.

"Thanks."

My eyes grew hot. I had fought my way through a 120-story skyscraper and around a thousand enemies without wavering once, but now my heart churned.

I thought of the silver-haired old butler collapsed against a snow-covered rock and continued.

"…For staying here all this time."

I meant every word. I was sincerely grateful to Go Jun.

Because he had stayed instead of running, I could end his life with my own hands.

Rrrrmmble!

My dantian was half empty after all the internal energy I had spent, but what remained was enough. A massive wave spread out from me and shook Area A.

For this moment, I could forget the fatigue of the endless battles and the growing weight of my limbs.

I'll kill him.

With that one thought, I stepped forward.

Flamefire Path.

Flames rose from the tips of my feet as I kicked off the ground and surged forward. They drove back the darkness that had conquered the corridor and illuminated the way.

At the far end, a figure was streaking across the corridor as a beam of light.

Go Jun.

I could see the red glow of his eyes between his clenched teeth and the helmet pulled low over his face.

The instant light flashed from the waist of the man charging toward me without hesitation, I raised White Flame's shaft.

Whoom, KABOOM!

Two enormous energies of different colors tangled amid the roar.

The collision sent a tremendous force back through my weapon. A wave of energy slashed in every direction like a blade.

Beyond our locked weapons, I saw his red eyes. Then his voice reached me.

"You're not much, are you? Don't you think?"

"…!"

My eyes widened despite myself.

His feet should have been knocked backward. Instead, they were planted firmly in the ground.

And that was not the only thing I had failed to anticipate.

Crunch. Crrrunch.

An unbelievable pressure traveled up White Flame's shaft. An enormous power, large enough that it would not have been strange for it to explode at any moment, continued to flow out and wrap around the sword blade.

Slowly, but without stopping, it continued to grow in size and crushed White Flame's shaft.

What is this?

I had never faced Force this immense—or rather, an Aura Blade of this magnitude.

At the sight of me frozen there, Go Jun's eyes filled with delight.

"You should've put that stupid head of yours to work and wondered why I stayed."

"You…!"

Before I could finish, the Aura Blade surrounding his sword swelled outward as if it had exploded.

Craaaack, KABOOM!

A roar left my ears ringing. A powerful shock swept through my body, and a red flash filled my vision as I flew backward.

Before I could fully feel the wind rushing past my ears, my back struck a solid marble wall.

KRAK!

The layers of defensive Magic surrounding it scattered, and the whole wall caved in.

I was embedded in the exact center of the wall, leaving behind a crater large enough for three or four people to stand inside. I blinked.

My vision trembled from the impact to my head. Through it, I saw Go Jun charging at me with his teeth bared.

“I’ll kill you.”

Whooooooosh!

He moved faster than he spoke. His sword cut diagonally down through the air, sending out a burst of red light.

Then, in the next instant, a crescent-shaped Aura Blade that had crossed dozens of meters[2683] came rushing right up to my face.

Slice! KRAAAAAASH!

I escaped by a hair.

My aching body moved on instinct, carrying me clear of the attack. Looking at the space the Aura Blade had shredded, I thought:

What if I’d tried to block that head-on?

The answer was easy enough.

I was more exhausted than I had realized.

Suppressing two Monster Waves had made me bear the full aftermath of One Annihilation. Then, from the moment I entered Ares Guild, I had fought while holding back enough to avoid killing most of my opponents.

Facing an attack like that head-on in my current condition would not have ended well.

“Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung.”

Go Jun hummed my name like a tune, then grinned.

“You should see your face. You’re no hero. You’re just a rat. You’ll die crying and begging for your life.”

I watched him approach, his voice almost cheerful. Then a thought struck me.

“Did you take something?”

“What?”

“No, wait. In this case, should I call it a Magic Gem instead of drugs?”

“…!”

At that moment, the smile on Go Jun’s lips faded.

I no longer needed an answer. His face had given me one.

“Hah.”

I let out a small, hollow laugh.

The rage that had paralyzed my mind and body for a moment began to fade, and only then was I finally able to see the cold reality in front of me.

“Of course. That’s how you did it.”

[2683] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–300 ft.

“Seeing someone in a new light” and “improving by leaps and bounds” were just four-character idioms. At least when it came to martial arts.

Martial strength had to be honed through training and real combat.

Even with the System, I could not have grown stronger at that rate. Go Jun certainly could not have done it.

No one became this strong in only two months.

There had only ever been one answer.

“You juiced up. You really did. You fucking idiot.”

I couldn’t hold back my laughter.

It wasn’t amusement. It was disgust. Go Jun had chosen to give up being human and become a monster, and the sheer stupidity of it kept making me laugh.

“Fuck, I’ve never seen an idiot like you. You couldn’t beat me any normal way, so you started sucking down Magic Gems? If you were going to do that, why not go to Magic Johnson? I bet that guy would’ve taken real good care of you with his magic wand.”

I had hit a nerve. Go Jun’s face went rigid, and his already-red eyes darkened further.

“Shut your fucking—”

“Just shut up and listen, you son of a bitch.”

Thud. Thud.

Rubble and chunks of marble fell away as I got up.

I cracked my stiff neck from side to side and stared at him.

“What? You set off a few Monster Waves with an S-grade Magic Gem and pissed yourself over how well it worked? Watched people die because you barely lifted a finger and thought you were a god? No, sir, you fucking moron. You’re just a monster. At best, you’re some idiot side character with a Named Monster for a constellation.[2684]”

“Shut up!”

“Fuck off. Want me to give it a title, too? *Go Jun Swallows an S-Grade Magic Gem.*”

“Jin Taekyuuung—!”

Fwooooooosh!

A gale rose with a tremendous wave of energy and swept through the area.

But I calmly answered as I watched that unprecedented power swell until it looked ready to burst.

“What, you fucking idiot?”

I had never been afraid. Now that I knew what he had become, I had no reason to hesitate.

[2684] In Korean fantasy fiction, a constellation is a powerful being who acts as a character’s patron.

He was a monster who had crossed the line, and he had to die by my hand today.

For the old butler who had fallen into a darkness from which he would never return. For the people and Hunters who had died in the Monster Waves.

And… for me, furious at this goddamned reality.

“You have to die.”

I bit out the words with all my heart. Go Jun’s blood-red figure blurred.

Whoooooosh! KABOOM!

The red Aura Blade stopped above my head.

The tremendous pressure transmitted through White Flame’s spearhead made my wrists throb, and my ankles sank deep into the ground.

But I did not give way. At least the power I wielded had been built through countless hours of training and insight, with the good fortune of the System added on top.

“Get lost, you drugged-up bastard.”

Rrrrmmble!

I grinned as I looked into Go Jun’s wide-open eyes, then thrust my fist forward with all my strength.

Wham!

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Wham!

My fist slammed into Go Jun's chest with a dull thud.

The layers of defensive Magic shattered at once, and part of his sturdy full-body armor caved inward. He gritted his teeth and roared.

"Jin Taekyung!"

That punch would have left most high-level Hunters or Peak masters with severe Internal Injury, unable to fight.

But Go Jun was different. Perhaps it was the Magic Gem's influence, but even my Inner-Family Heavy Hand had failed to do much damage.

An S-rank Hunter. And more.

Whatever else had happened, he was already a recognized S-rank Hunter. He had learned an internal cultivation technique—what the modern world called a mana cultivation technique—and absorbed the energy of an S-grade Magic Gem from a Named Monster. His strength was immense.

"Die!"

Whoooooom! KABOOM!

The energy had gone beyond red. Now the color of blood, it burst outward like an explosion.

White Flame's shaft trembled under the mountain of pressure bearing down from the enormous Aura Blade.

I haven't been pushed this hard in a long time.

Right now, even three jiazi[2685] of internal energy and physical abilities beyond human limits felt inadequate.

Maybe it was the fatigue I'd built up over the course of the day. Or maybe Go Jun had absorbed that much magical power.

One thing was certain: this idiot had gained far more strength than I'd expected.

Rrrrrumble. Crack!

The tremendous pressure drove me and the ground beneath me downward. By the time I was buried up to my ankles, Go Jun was baring his teeth in a grin.

"Starting to get it? Hmm? Finally feel like you're fucked?"

He gave a low laugh.

He was enjoying this. He thought he was finally going to avenge his Master.

"Ever since the day my Master died, I've killed you every night. Over and over. I've lived for a moment like this."

I watched for an opening as I answered.

[2685] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi are 180 years.

“No wonder I felt like I’d been born again every morning. I thought I was just waking up refreshed from dreaming about Jungryong dying every night.”

Fwoosh!

The instant his blood-red energy wavered, I yanked my foot free and kicked upward.

Boom!

My toes, swinging like a beam of light, were blocked by his shin with a thunderous crash. Go Jun, who had been about to pour out his anger, let out a hollow laugh.

“It’s too late to struggle. Now that it’s come to this, killing the rest of them will be easy.”

“What?”

I blinked, not quite understanding him. Then his quiet voice reached my ear.

“You and that goddamned Peace Guild. Your parents and that bitch of a little sister waiting at home… Ah. Your father’s already dead, isn’t he? Doesn’t matter. If he were still alive, he’d be following his son to the grave soon enough.”

“…”

“Did you like having the world call you a hero? Think you’d all live happily ever after? It’s bullshit. Kim Hwajong, that old man, was only the beginning.”

His sticky, unpleasant breath touched my face. He cackled.

“This time it’s you, then Choi Minwoo. After that, I don’t care who it is. I’ll kill everyone with even the slightest connection to you, one by one. Sweeping them all away with a Monster Wave sounds good, too. What do you think?”

I stared at him, blinking as he went on.

What the fuck is this bastard saying?

It was strange. The thing in front of me looked human, but all that came out of its mouth was the sound of a dog barking.

Here stood a monster in a human shell.

He’s going to kill them? All my people?

I felt sick.

Go Jun could make good on those words. I hated that he could. And when I pictured the people I couldn’t live without lying dead, my mind went blank.

Mother. Hayeon. Team Leader Choi. Uncle Kkeokjeong, Song Song, Jinho hyung[2686]*…*

Their faces flashed before my eyes, one after another. So did the graying old butler who had died on the snow-covered mountain.

He’s going to kill them all, and he wants to know what I think?

My answer came out calm.

“Fine. I understand.”

[2686] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older male friend.

"What?"

"Go ahead. Try it."

The smile on Go Jun's face faded. I drew on every bit of strength I had.

Grrrrrkk.

The spear, slowly sinking under the pressure, stopped. So did my bending knees.

For that moment, I forgot my fatigue. My muscles still ached as though they might tear from the lingering aftermath of One Annihilation, but I forgot the pain, too.

The anger layered over my fatigue and pain covered and paralyzed everything else.

Internal energy boiled like lava through my Eight Extraordinary Meridians and hundreds of acupoints.

When I spoke, my voice burned.

"You shouldn't have said that."

"…!"

"You shouldn't have talked about my people that way. At the very least, you shouldn't have."

I'd suspected it. Go Jun was capable of doing exactly what he'd threatened.

But suspecting it myself and hearing it directly from his mouth were entirely different matters.

"Don't you think, you inhuman piece of shit?"

Go Jun was a monster. Whether he'd always been one or I'd made him into one no longer mattered.

He had to die for my people to live. And they had to live for me to live.

Grrrrrrkk!

I hauled my foot out of the ground and straightened my knee.

Putting my back and arms into it, I drove the spear shaft up against the Aura Blade's pressure.

Slowly. Little by little. Without stopping.

"How are you…?"

As Go Jun's eyes widened, I whispered a command in my mind.

Inventory open. Store White Flame.

Pop.

It happened in an instant.

The spear and the blue-white flames holding back the enormous Aura Blade vanished. With nothing opposing it, the blood-red energy plunged straight down.

Whoooooom! Slice!

It cleaved through the space where I'd stood. But I was already gone.

Dozens of hairs, severed by the sword pressure, scattered past my shoulder. My fist was already deep inside Go Jun's guard, wreathed in blue-white hellfire.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

The world slowed. Space warped in the ultra-high temperature heat. It looked almost like the expression Go Jun was making now.

"No—"

Too late.

I answered without a sound and threw my punch.

Fwoosh! KABOOM!

The impact drowned out the rest of his cry. My fist burned through the air and struck his solar plexus, sending him flying like a cannonball.

I launched myself after him.

Whooooooosh!

Wind rushed past my ears.

In less than an instant, I covered more than ten meters[2687] and overtook him. As he hurtled toward me, I clasped my hands together and brought them down like a hammer.

CRASH! KRAKAKAK!

The blow struck his abdomen. Already battered, the upper half of his armor melted under the Scorching Yang Qi.

Go Jun hit the ground on his back and smashed through it. Blood erupted from his mouth.

Pshhh!

I moved to drive my fist into him while he was down, but the blood he spat drenched me.

My vision turned red. I faltered for a fraction of a second, and my senses screamed a warning.

Danger!

He hadn't spat blood by accident. It was part of his attack.

I kicked off the ground the instant I realized it. Red energy shot toward me as I retreated.

Shhk! Slice!

Heat seared my side.

I'd moved as fast as I could, but the Aura surging from the sword Go Jun had never let go of was too large to evade completely.

Drip. Drip-drip.

I pressed a hand to my bleeding side and wiped the blood from my eyes.

[2687] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

Go Jun was already on his feet and charging, his helmet discarded.

His furious shout rang through the devastated corridor.

“You fucking bastard!”

Whoooooosh!

Blood-red Aura burst from the tip of his sword and tore through the air.

I narrowly avoided it with a series of backward steps, then flung both arms out.

With the Magic only I could use.

Inventory open. Summon.

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

A moment ago, my hands had been empty. Now dagger handles met my palms, and the blades flew from my grasp.

Streaks of light shot toward Go Jun. He hurriedly turned his sword sideways, holding the blade across his front.

Clang-clang-clang-clang!

Four daggers bounced off it and lodged in the walls and ceiling. I drew up my internal energy and sent it into my legs. Flames rose from the foot I set forward.

Flamefire Path.

Fwoosh! Whoooooosh!

I became a streak of flame racing toward Go Jun. Seeing me charge without my spear, he roared.

“I’ll kill you!”

His eyes were blood-red now, their glow bright in the darkness.

Then an energy unlike anything he’d unleashed before burst from his body and swept in every direction.

WHOOOOOOOOOM!

It was a raging storm, a fog with no way out. Far from tiring, he was giving off an even stronger wave of energy.

I kept going, shooting through that murky, violent fog of magical power.

Go Jun charged through it toward me.

Zzzzzzzzz!

His Aura Blade, an absurd two meters[2688] long, came cleaving through the air.

Each time I twisted aside to avoid it, the sword pressure carving up the space around me tore my skin and drew blood.

That was fine. As long as I didn’t fall.

As long as I could bring him down, make him pay for Kim Hwajong’s death, and protect everyone still alive from another threat.

Slice!

[2688] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.

A burning pain swept across my chest.

My clothes and armor had long since been torn away in the fight. A thin line appeared on my bare skin, then reddened.

Fwoosh!

Blood spurted from my chest. The cut was shallow, but the immense energy forcing its way through it made my vision swim.

I steadied myself and kicked off the ground.

Boom!

I shot forward, leaving the crash behind me. At the end of my path stood a monster who had chosen to stop being human.

“Jin Taekyuuung!”

Go Jun charged with his sword held upright. The Aura Blade around it had turned a murky, dark red.

The closer I got, the more clearly I felt that sticky, unpleasant energy.

That isn’t mana anymore.

The world had another name for energy so corrupted and ominous, the opposite of pure mana.

Magical power.

The moment the words came to mind, I knew I had to use everything I had.

Go Jun and me. Me and Go Jun.

We were close enough to kill each other now.

I could see the fury in his eyes and smell the stench on his hot breath.

And then…

We extended our arms almost at the same time.

Shhk!

The world slowed to a crawl. The wind split, and space vanished between us.

Faint delight spread across Go Jun’s face as he thrust his sword toward my chest.

I’ve won.

That was what his eyes seemed to say.

I was empty-handed. His sword was wrapped in murky magical power, with strength and reach on its side. Of course he thought he’d won.

He was wrong.

Inventory open. Summon.

Thought was faster than light, and the System answered without hesitation.

White Flame appeared in my hand as though it had been there all along.

Blue-white hellfire coated its transparent spearhead.

Fwoosh!

The searing heat burned through the air.

The spear had started after Go Jun's sword, yet it slipped past the murky Aura Blade and reached its target first.

Squelch!

Flesh parted with a sickening sound, followed by the smell of it burning.

Go Jun's eyes bulged. There was no delight left in them.

He stared down at the spear piercing his chest, shock and pain filling his eyes, and forced out a few words.

"What… is this?"

I answered calmly.

"Striking Second, Hitting First. You got your strength from a Magic Gem. You wouldn't understand it even if you died and came back."

Every fight, every movement, had a flow.

Know your opponent's movement, predict it, and you could reach your target first even if you started later.

Training and experience had taught me the principle of Striking Second, Hitting First. Go Jun had pursued nothing but greater power.

That was what decided this fight.

"Idiot. You should've used that rock of a head at least once to think about why your dead Master never recommended Magic Gems to you in the first place."

"…!"

At the anger and disgust in my voice, Go Jun's eyes trembled as if he'd accepted his fate.

Then the sword that had fallen short of me shot upward like lightning.

Shing!

It happened in an instant. Murky energy—much smaller than before—gathered at its tip and thrust toward my heart.

A fraction of an instant earlier, I'd spoken another command in my mind.

Inventory open. Summon.

KRAK!

The concentrated energy, with all its destructive force and cutting power, struck an obstacle.

Go Jun's eyes widened again. Reflected in them was armor with a faint red glow.

Fire Dragon Armor.

"What, what is this…?"

"What do you think, idiot? Life insurance."

I'd kept Fire Dragon Armor hidden all the way to the top floor, even after taking that shallow cut across my chest, for a moment just like this.

And I'd been right.

“You… What the hell are you…?”
I looked into his frightened eyes.
The eyes of a human—no, a monster—driven to the edge.
Then I drove the spear deeper into Go Jun’s chest.
KRAK!

Chapter 594

Crack!

The grisly sound came with a sensation I had felt hundreds—thousands—of times before, traveling up through my fingertips.

Flesh splitting. Bone breaking.

Somewhere along the way, I had grown used to it. Sometimes that left a bitter taste in my mouth. Being used to it meant I had taken that many lives with my own hands.

But not this time. As I looked down at the dying man, I felt no bitterness at all.

"Kh…!"

A final groan escaped with a deflating sound. At the same time, the solidly built man dropped to his knees.

Thud.

The blood-red glow in his eyes, once chilling to look at, slowly faded. His whole body trembled before the death closing in on him.

No. Perhaps it wasn't death itself that Go Jun feared. Perhaps it was me, the one who had dealt it to him.

"J-Jin Taekyung."

His voice was fading, and so was the light in his eyes. I felt no pity.

He wasn't human like me. He was a monster.

The Peace Guild had lost Kim Hwajong today. Thousands of people whose names I would never know had lost family and friends they loved. For the madness Go Jun had caused, this death almost seemed too easy.

"Cough. I-I can't die like this…"

I looked down coldly at him as he knelt there, convulsing in pain.

"Die. Oxygen is wasted on a piece of shit like you."

I had no intention of listening to a long-winded final speech, or giving him the chance to make one. I wrenched White Flame from his chest.

Fwoosh!

The moment the transparent spearhead came free, the blood that had not yet evaporated sprayed out like a fountain.

Go Jun stared blankly up at me, a fist-sized hole in his chest. Then his body slowly tipped over.

Splash.

That was the end. His face fell into a pool of his own blood, and he stopped moving, eyes still wide open.

As I looked at the monster's corpse, with no breath or trace of life left in it, a thought came to me.

It's over.

Lee Jungryong's loyal Disciple of several decades—the man who had effectively ruled Ares Guild, one of the foremost Guilds in the world—had died by my hand.

He had deliberately caused two Monster Waves, leaving thousands dead or injured and costing Kim Hwajong and some twenty Peace Guild members their lives. He had paid for it with his own.

So this really is the end…

Then why did I feel so hollow? I had taken my revenge, yet it felt as though the hole was in my chest, not Go Jun's.

It was probably because I knew that the people who had left my side would never return.

Are you still cold? Is it still dark?

I turned away, asking questions that could never reach them.

Fatigue and drowsiness weighed on me more heavily than I could have imagined. I fought them off and slowly crossed the dark corridor, wrecked by our battle.

Step.

With every step, faces and memories rose before my eyes and obscured my vision.

I saw Gwangan Bridge collapsing. I heard people screaming in terror. A family photograph dangling from a car's rearview mirror brought back a promise I had made long ago, pinkies linked with someone I missed more than words could say.

"When Hayeon gets a little older, and you, Taekyung, start middle school, let's come see the sea again. All right?"

"Really?"

"Of course. Come on, pinky promise."

But today, the place from the promise I had kept deep in my heart had collapsed.

Innocent people had died, and monsters had spread like a plague. I had done everything I could, but I hadn't saved more of them.

Step.

My thoughts were as unsteady as my feet. Through the confusion, a warm voice echoed in my mind.

"It wasn't your fault."

"…!"

"You did your best."

The graying old butler who had comforted me even as he died had gone somewhere he could never return from.

I had no way of knowing whether it was night or day where he had arrived. Whether it was cold or warm. I could only hope that his world was a little brighter. That he, who had shivered in the cold, was somewhere warmer.

And… that he had believed my lie to the very end—the lie that the person he had wanted to see one last time had come.

Step.

There is no process without a result. Someone had to pay the price. I believed it was only natural to be punished for doing wrong.

That was why I had come here. I had thrown open the gates of a palace no one had dared approach and brought down an impregnable fortress.

I had fought, and fought, and fought again. And after finally killing the monster wearing a human face, I suddenly felt hollow inside and found myself wondering:

What am I supposed to do now?

I had thought that killing Go Jun, the cause of it all, would ease my anger, even a little. I had thought I might laugh out loud with relief.

But that wasn't what happened.

With one gesture, I could make a massive pit and fill it again. But I couldn't fill the empty place in my heart.

It had been the same three years ago. It was the same now.

Damn it.

My mouth tasted bitter. In the end, the wounds were left for those of us still here to bear.

I almost regretted giving Go Jun such a painless death.

Step.

I stopped.

At some point, an inexplicable sense that something was wrong had taken hold of me. A chill crept up my spine.

What is this feeling?

Was it the exhaustion? Or everything weighing on my mind? My thoughts were as murky as fog.

I stood there for a moment. Then I realized what was wrong.

Go Jun should be dead. So why…

Why hadn't the System window announcing the kill appeared?

I had driven a spearhead into the center of his chest and burned his organs. I had watched his face fall into the pool of blood and felt him stop breathing.

"Don't tell me."

I muttered the words and turned around. An unusually deep darkness had settled over the ruined corridor.

The System was absolute, and it was immediate.

I knew that better than anyone. I simply had not noticed anything strange because I had been overwhelmed by exhaustion and deep thoughts in the moment of victory.

So when I found the pool of blood empty, I was not especially surprised.

He's alive. Go Jun is alive.

That much was certain. What I wanted to know was how.

There had been only two of us in Area A: Go Jun and me. He had been dead. His heart had stopped, and he had stopped breathing. Even a half-body bath in top-grade potion could not have brought him back.

Then how?

I followed the traces he had left behind.

Area A was a maze, fitting for a secret zone open to only a handful of people. But the trail of blood led in one direction, and it was easy enough to follow.

I moved quickly, taking in what I saw.

No one helped him. He didn't have time to cover his tracks, either.

The marks told me he had been desperate. I could almost see him crawling alone, pressed flat against the floor, struggling to keep going.

And then…

He got to his feet. Right here.

Two clear footprints stood out in the blood. Countless handprints marked the wall beside them.

What had happened to him? Why had he been writhing in pain?

Before long, I found the answer.

That's…

Blood.

Not the bright red of human blood. Drops of monster blood tinged blue.

There was no mistaking what that meant. I stared at the monster blood on my hand, then shot forward.

Whoosh!

The wind rushed past me, carrying a strong scent of blood and a foul stench. Even through my exhaustion, I could sense someone drawing closer.

Then I entered another corridor and saw him with my own eyes.

He looked nothing like he had the last time I saw him.

"Go Jun."

My quiet voice echoed down the corridor. Go Jun—or rather, the *monster*—turned as he staggered along.

"Krrk. Kurruk."

Whatever he was trying to say came out as a metallic rasp. Compared with the rest of him, that was nothing.

He stood four meters[2689] tall. His arms and legs were grotesquely swollen, as if they might burst. His body looked like creatures of different species had been thrown together, each part bearing its own shape and features.

Only his face had kept anything like its original form: a human face half-covered in scales, with blood-red eyes shining between them.

"Jin… Taekyung. Karruk."

Fear and hatred mingled in his eyes as he looked at me. I took in the sight of him from head to toe and spoke with disgust.

"Did you want to live that badly? Even if it meant becoming a monster?"

"Shut… up. This… this wasn't what I wanted either—"

Crack! KRAK!

It happened in an instant.

Before he could finish, his right arm suddenly bent as if an invisible hand had twisted it. Blue blood burst from the break.

"GRAAAAH!"

As he screamed, his grotesque body began changing rapidly.

Shlk. Crackle!

The thick skin covered in hide and scales like a monster's began to heal, while his crushed joints fitted themselves back together like puzzle pieces.

"Hah. Hah."

Go Jun panted, still in pain. Watching him, I began to understand how he had made it this far.

"Troll. Right?"

"…!"

His eyelids trembled at the question. I had my answer.

Trolls had extraordinary regenerative abilities. The Named Monster that had originally owned the S-grade Magic Gem Go Jun had absorbed must have been an immensely powerful Troll.

And…

The S-grade Magic Gem he absorbed wasn't the only one, was it?

One look at him was enough to tell me. His swollen body and incredible regeneration were Troll traits, but the scales and hide covering half of him had come from another monster.

Mutation. That's what he's become.

Unlike mana, magical power was dark and turbid. It corrupted humans. After absorbing two S-grade Magic Gems packed with it, of course the forces inside him would clash.

[2689] Four meters is about 13 ft.

“Kurruk. I could have been stronger. Stronger than this. But you. You…”

I cut him off.

“Not stronger. You would’ve become an even more horrifying monster. Look at yourself.”

“…!”

“You’re worse than a monster. You’re no Hunter, no human—just a monster. That’s what you are.”

Step.

I moved toward him. Go Jun stared at me, eyes wide, and shouted as though he were screaming.

“Don’t come closer! Krrk! Stay away!”

“That’s a problem. There’s a monster right in front of me.”

“T-This can’t be!”

His blood-red eyes filled with fear.

He must have known it, too. His body was showing signs of falling apart while he stood still. There was no way he could fight me in that condition.

Tap-tap-tap!

When Go Jun turned and ran, I wasn’t surprised. I reversed my grip on White Flame’s shaft and hurled it.

SHWAAAAK! BOOM!

A streak of flame-wreathed light burst through his legs and buried itself in the ground. He screamed and thrashed, both legs gone, while flesh and bone rapidly grew from the severed ends.

I wasn’t going to stand there and watch.

“Go on. Regenerate. Keep doing it as long as you can.”

Thud!

Drawing up the internal energy I had left, I rushed him. I planted my foot on his back, grabbed both of his thick arms, and pulled.

Crack. KRAKAKAK!

Go Jun lost both arms after his legs, and his scream rang through the corridor.

I didn’t blink. I kept moving.

Slice! Stab!

I pulled the spear from the ground and slashed and stabbed his body in several places. I seared the sections trying to regenerate with the Flame Divine Palm, then gripped them tightly and tore them apart.

Under ordinary circumstances, I would never have done anything so brutal. Now I did not hesitate.

KRAKAKAK!

Regeneration. Destruction. Again and again.

Go Jun was the first to give out under the endless pain.

“GRAAAAH! S-Stop!”

His voice was hoarse, and his eyes were not as red as before. His regeneration had been slowing for some time. Now it had stopped altogether.

“Now… kill me…”

“I was going to.”

This time, I would make sure he could never come back.

I looked into his eyes.

“Whether you’re going to heaven or hell, go on ahead and wait for me. When I get there, I’ll kill you to my heart’s content.”

“…!”

Those were the last words Go Jun heard in this world.

It ends now.

I did not wait for an answer. Without a moment’s hesitation, I brought the transparent spearhead down.

Slice! Thud!

His head came free with a sharp cutting sound and rolled across the floor.

That was the end of the monster who had become neither a hero like Cheon Taemin nor an ambitious warlord like his Master, Lee Jungryong.

Ding.

The familiar chime rang in my ears. I picked up Go Jun’s head from the pool of blood and crossed the space where I alone remained, my steps slow and unsteady.

I was tired.

Chapter 595

Unlike the way in, the journey back was long and hard.

Exhaustion made my body feel like waterlogged cotton, and my eyelids kept falling shut.

I want to collapse right here.

But I couldn't. I still had somewhere to go. First, though, I had to drive off the hyenas who had caught the scent of trouble and gathered in front of me.

Quite a crowd.

I staggered out of Area A and looked around through half-closed eyes.

I was back in the spacious hall on the top floor. Around two hundred Ares Guild members waited there, their faces tense.

Then I spotted a familiar face at the front and sighed.

"Maybe I should've just killed you."

The middle-aged man at the front, Head of Security Go Se-won, answered in a calm voice after hearing my mutter.

"Yes. That wouldn't have been a bad choice either."

He looked fully recovered. He must have received treatment while I was gone. Gazing at the sword in his hand, he went on.

"It must have been thirty years ago when I first picked up a sword. I was trained even before I awakened. And on the day I awakened as an A-rank Hunter, the former Vice Guild Master gave me this sword as a gift. The other members of the security team probably received theirs the same way."

That didn't surprise me. Team Leader Choi had told me Lee Jungryong took in war orphans after the Great Cataclysm and trained them as his personal guards according to their mana affinity.

The man in front of me was one of them.

"So, are you going to avenge that grudge now?"

"…That grudge."

Go Se-won murmured the words, then asked, "Before that, tell me one thing. Why did you spare me?"

I thought for a moment.

"I figured you should at least get to answer the phone."

"What?"

"You should at least have told your family you were working late. Or that you weren't coming home. My father couldn't do either. I thought he'd come home when the time came, but… he never did. Now I can barely remember his voice."

"…"

Maybe I was tired. I'd said more than I needed to. I clicked my tongue, and Go Se-won studied me for a moment before asking, "What about the Vice Guild Master?"

Instead of answering, I shrugged. It had been a fight that could only end with one of us dead. But I was the only one who had appeared.

"He's dead, then," Go Se-won muttered.

"Go up and check. It's quite a sight."

The Ares Guild members surrounding us stirred at once. Several executives who were plainly loyalists urged Go Se-won on through clenched teeth.

"Team Leader Go, what are you waiting for?"

"Eliminate him immediately!"

"I've already told you. Kill Jin Taekyung, and we won't hold you responsible for revealing Area A's location. The Guild will reward you handsomely, too. You could even put yourself forward for the next Vice Guild Master."

Anger and temptation mingled in their voices.

As Go Se-won stood silently among them, I rubbed my stiff, tired eyes and spoke.

"I'm exhausted. If you're done asking questions, let's get this over with. I've got somewhere to be."

His sharp gaze traveled over me.

"Even someone like you seems to be having a hard time in your current condition."

"That's my problem, not yours."

"…Fair enough."

Go Se-won replied quietly. Then, just as his fingers toyed with the hilt of his sword —

Whoosh! Slice!

Blood sprayed. One of the executives fell, eyes wide at the unexpected strike. It was the man who had just offered Go Se-won the Vice Guild Master position.

"You crazy—!"

"What the hell are you doing?"

"T-Team Leader Go!"

As the executives shouted, Go Se-won turned the area into chaos in a single instant and spoke in an even voice.

"Subdue them all. The fight is over."

The executives here had plenty to lose. The other Guild members didn't. They had no direct ties to Go Jun and no reason to take a needless risk—especially against a monster who had wrecked Ares Guild headquarters single-handedly.

Clatter-clatter-clang!

"…!"

Weapons were leveled from every direction the moment Go Se-won spoke. Realizing they had no chance, the loyalist executives lowered their own with a groan.

Go Se-won turned to me. “That was quick enough, wasn’t it?”

“You…”

I was about to say something, but then I nodded.

“Looks like sparing you paid off.”

“Thirty years,” he said. “That’s how long I’ve lived as a hunting dog. I’ve done enough.”

“A late change of heart?”

“I don’t know. I’m not that good a man. But it doesn’t matter anymore. It’s been more than I could bear for a while now.”

Apparently, I wasn’t the only one who was tired. Go Se-won surveyed the chaos with weary eyes, then stepped aside.

“Go. No one will stop you.”

I didn’t refuse and began walking. Just as I was about to pass by Go Se-won, a quiet murmur reached my ears.

“…Thank you for the call.”

That was enough. I gave him a small nod and walked past him and the two hundred or so Ares Guild members.

Step. Step.

I dragged my exhausted body onward, walking and walking. I had to meet someone before sunset.

I don’t remember how I reached my destination. Only fragments remain.

The troops surrounding the devastated Ares Guild headquarters. Combat drones filling the sky.

President Baek Hanseong’s rigid face as he arrived under heavy guard, despite his aides’ attempts to stop him.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, what in the world…?”

He couldn’t finish. I offered to surrender peacefully on one condition, and after giving it some thought, President Baek agreed to my request.

That was why I was here.

“Hey, you!”

“T-Taekyung!”

Familiar faces approached through my blurred vision. I wanted to smile and wave, but my body wouldn’t cooperate.

My legs buckled. Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong hurried to catch me.

“Sorry. My legs gave out.”

“How can you say that right now…?”

Song Song pressed her lips together before she could finish. She rubbed at her reddened eyes.

“What about my family?” I asked. “They’re not here, are they?”

“Are you insane?”

“I sent Guild members to bring them somewhere safe,” she continued, her voice hoarse. “Luckily, your mother was in the middle of cooking and didn’t know anything. Hayeon, who’s with her… is pretending she doesn’t know.”

Relief washed over me. I couldn’t imagine how badly the news about me would have shaken my mother.

Hayeon was there, though. She’d handle it. She had always been more thoughtful than I was.

“And Team Leader Choi is safe,” Song Song added. “He still hasn’t regained consciousness.”

“Thanks. For looking after him.”

“You…”

Song Song was looking at me with a complicated expression when Im Kkeokjeong’s shoulders began to shake.

“I’m sorry, Taekyung. I’m so sorry…”

What did he have to be sorry for? Why was he so sad?

I wanted to answer his sobs, but my throat closed up. I knew exactly how he felt. The helplessness and guilt of being unable to do a thing—there were no words for it.

Song Song had turned away, too. Tears slipped down her cheeks.

Damn it.

I clenched my teeth and tried to ignore the heat in my eyes. Then I managed to force out a question.

“What about him… Butler Kim?”

“He’s been waiting. All this time.”

The answer came from neither Im Kkeokjeong nor Song Song. I turned my head and saw a blond foreigner standing in front of a door.

“So you’ve come, wicked human.”

The Skeleton King’s voice sounded far away. I had seen the sign before I saw his face.

Morgue

My heart sank. As I stood frozen, the Skeleton King opened the door.

And through the gap in the open door… I saw the body of a person covered in a pure white sheet.

“It is impolite to keep the dead waiting, human.”

“…!”

“Do you intend to send him off like this?”

At those words, I left Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong behind and forced my unmoving feet forward.

The door closed quietly behind me. In the chill of the morgue, it was only him and me. Just the two of us.

Swish.

With trembling hands, I drew back the white sheet.

Kim Hwajong had died with a faint smile on his face.

He looked as though he were having a pleasant dream. But I knew that dream would never end.

He would never again greet me in a pressed suit, smiling gently. He would never again get up early and offer me coffee.

Today, he had said goodbye to us. Now we had to let him go.

Drip. Drop.

Something hot rolled down both my cheeks. They were the first tears I had shed today, and tears I must never shed again.

I swear.

It felt like being taken back three years. Regret came with a vow.

I’m sorry. I won’t let anyone else go the way you did.

So please…

“Rest in peace.”

With those quiet, heartfelt words, I took Go Jun’s head out of my Inventory and set it on the floor.

So the monster who had died with his eyes wide open might understand what he had done. So Kim Hwajong might rest a little easier.

It was the promise I had made to myself while holding the old butler’s hand as it slowly grew cold on the snow-covered mountain.

Fwoosh.

As if in answer, Kim Hwajong’s face flushed red. Violet sunset light streamed through the morgue window.

I gazed at its beauty through blurred eyes and felt the strength leave my body.

Ah.

I had reached my limit, body and heart alike.

I leaned my back against the wall and sank down as if collapsing. Accepting the

sleep pressing down on me with a weight greater than Taishan[2690], I thought:

Today was a long day.

Click.

The firmly shut door opened with a faint sound.

A slender beauty, a middle-aged man who looked like a bandit, and a blond foreigner who might have stepped out of a magazine saw the severed head first and startled. Then they saw the peaceful face of the dead man and felt sorrow. Last, they saw the young man asleep where he had collapsed, and fell silent.

Jin Taekyung.

Indescribable emotions filled the three pairs of eyes gazing at him.

What more could they say?

Today, he had fought desperately against disaster and threats. He had made himself an outlaw and exacted the price for an innocent death.

There was only one thing they could do for him now.

Sleep well. Don’t worry about what comes next.

The fire would spread in every direction. No one knew where it would die down.

Even if the whole world condemned him for what had happened today—even if the authorities branded him a criminal—they would stand beside Jin Taekyung.

They would protect him, no matter what.

Just as you did for us.

Warm sunset light spread through the morgue.

One person’s long day had ended, but the day of the other three had not. No—in fact, they were about to become even busier.

[2690]Taishan, or Mount Tai, is a mountain in China. Its name is used here to evoke an immense weight.

Chapter 596

Just because the sun had set and the second hand had passed midnight didn't mean the day was over.

As long as people were awake and there was an interesting story to follow, their day went on.

That was how it happened on a bitterly cold, windy afternoon in mid-January.

[Breaking News] S-Rank Hunter Jin Taekyung Launches Solo Assault on Ares Guild Headquarters

The breaking news threw Korea into an uproar. No—the entire world was shaken.

Almost as soon as it broke, posts and comments flooded websites everywhere.

> └ Hey, what is this?
>
> └ What is?
>
> └ I got a sudden alert and checked it out, and… holy shit, Lord Fuck[2691] supposedly stormed Ares Guild headquarters alone?
>
> └ ???
>
> └ ??????
>
> └ Quit talking bullshit, lol. I was watching the news just now, and they were looking for Lord Fuck[2692] because he disappeared from Pyeongchang. So why is he suddenly storming Ares Guild headquarters—
>
> └ Fuck, it's real. What the hell is this?

> └ ?? What is this, *The Truman Show*? You're not doing this to fool newbies like me, are you?
>
> └ If it were *The Truman Show*, at least the ratings would be good. Why would we bother fooling you? It's real. Turn on WBS—they've got an exclusive report. The Capital Defense Command[2693] has been dispatched and everything's going crazy;
>
> └ Why would the fire department be involved?
>
> └ Not the fire department. The Capital Defense Command[2694];

[2691] "Lord Fuck" and "Lord Sibu-leol" are online nicknames drawn from Taekyung's profanity during a public broadcast. *Sibu-leol* represents a Korean swear word.

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[2693] The Korean abbreviation for Capital Defense Command, *subangsa*, sounds similar to *sobangseo*, meaning fire station.

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> ㄴ I get that Lord Sibu-leol[2695] went to Ares Guild headquarters, but isn't saying he "stormed the place" a bit much? Maybe he went to have tea with Go Jun.
>
> ㄴ Probably not. There were more than a thousand witnesses, and apparently Jin Taekyung punched the Ares headquarters building right in the solar plexus before going inside. Even if he went for tea, I bet every teacup in there got smashed.
>
> ㄴ Got proof? If more than a thousand people saw it, someone must've taken a video. Post a link.
>
> ㄴ The thousand witnesses part is real, but apparently nobody took a video or even a picture. They said they only came to their senses after Lord Fuck[2696] went inside. Before that, they just watched like they were possessed.
>
> ㄴ ?? Lol. That many people and not one piece of evidence? Sounds like a false report.
>
> ㄴ Yeah. Why would Lord Fuck[2697] go there after disappearing for a while? Even if he did go, the rest sounds like rumors. Feels like the media's using rumors as kindling.

Immediately after the media began broadcasting the breaking news on a massive scale, most people refused to believe the shocking report.

A hero who had put down two monster waves in succession and then vanished had supposedly stormed Ares Guild, of all places, alone. It made no sense.

But within minutes, Jongno was designated a temporary disaster zone. Hunters and troops from the Capital Defense Command[2698] began evacuating civilians and establishing a defensive line, and the mood changed completely.

> ㄴ I think this might actually be real.
>
> ㄴ Damn, what the hell is going on?
>
> ㄴ Why all of a sudden…
>
> ㄴ I'm living in the United States. They're broadcasting breaking news here, too. Every major news program, including CNN and FOX, is monitoring the situation.

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> ㄴSeems like it’s the same all over the world, not just the United States. Korea and the foreign media are both going crazy;

Everyone who heard the news, at home and abroad, felt the atmosphere grow heavy.

President Baek Hanseong delivered an emergency letter concerning the current situation to the media, while experts in every field busied themselves analyzing the situation and its causes.

But before a complete answer could be found, the person at the center and beginning of everything revealed himself.

“Hunter Jin Taekyung.”

President Baek Hanseong stepped forward despite his aides’ attempts to stop him. At his call, the young man raised his head. Cameras carried both their faces across Korea and around the world.

Jin Taekyung. It was him.

Red and blue blood—human and monster—covered him from head to toe. He looked exhausted, and his eyes held a sadness no one could name.

His voice came out bleakly through dry, cracked lips.

“I… only did what I had to do.”

That was all the people staring at the screen, having forgotten even how to breathe, were allowed to see.

The live broadcast was cut off immediately at the Blue House’s request. For some reason, reporters from around the world who had been at the scene said nothing more.

At the end of that day, one enormous question remained.

Jin Taekyung and Ares Guild. Ares Guild and Jin Taekyung.

An unprecedented clash between one man and an organization.

No one could say for certain what had happened inside. But the effects of a battle lasting roughly an hour had swept through Jongno, and Jin Taekyung had walked out on his own two feet to stand before them all.

Two names with enormous influence in Korea and across the world had collided for reasons unknown. The individual had won.

That was shocking enough when the organization in question was Ares Guild. But what everyone wanted to know most was *why*.

Why had a man in his twenties, newly established as both a powerful Hunter and a young hero, gone to Ares Guild alone?

That night, a major news outlet broke the guidelines agreed upon in advance and set fire to the powder keg.

[Exclusive Report] Hunter Go Jun (Current Ares Vice Guild Master) and 25 Others Confirmed Dead; Total Casualties Around 500

[Chief Editorial Writer Lee Kanghee—Jin Taekyung: The Hero's Hidden Side. The Devil's Face.]

It was a bombshell.

Two monster waves unlike anything seen since the Great Cataclysm had struck in succession. Before the shock of them could fade, this new explosion shook everything again.

The whole of Korea boiled like a furnace beneath a bed of charcoal, and the heat spread throughout the world.

Midnight passed. The hours before dawn wore on. Still, the uproar showed no sign of subsiding.

The barrage, once begun, seemed as if it would never end.

Some condemned Jin Taekyung as a devil. Others submitted formal petitions demanding that he be executed.

But not everyone pointed a finger at him. In fact, most people still held a mixture of belief and doubt.

The belief that Jin Taekyung, who had accomplished so much, couldn't possibly have done such a thing.

The suspicion that media reports without an official announcement were nothing more than nonsense.

Those unbelievable hours passed, and morning came.

[Close Aide of the Late Hunter Go Jun, a Mr. Go, Turns Himself In]

[Official Blue House Press Conference at 10:00 a.m. Draws Worldwide Attention]

Then came a downpour that dampened the fierce flames of condemnation.

And through the rain that fell without pause for two full days—from the media and from the sky—one person finally woke.

Drip. Drip-drip-drip.

At the sudden sound of rain, I blinked blankly.

As my vision cleared, the first thing I saw was an ornate, magnificent painting.

I knew that ceiling. I knew the painting. I'd heard about it so many times that it would have been strange not to recognize it.

Michelangelo's The Creation (The Genesis).

Only then did I realize I was lying in Team Leader Choi's mansion.

I turned my head. Raindrops tapped against the window that took up an entire wall.

No way.

A single thought flashed through my empty mind, and my heart began pounding violently.

What if—against all odds—it had all been a nightmare? What if nothing had happened yet, and I had only just left Henan and logged out?

The absurd hope burst like a bubble a moment later.

"You're awake. I'd just come to check on you. I'm glad."

A smooth, low voice. Younger than Butler Kim's, and impossible to read.

How had I failed to notice him until now?

I clenched my teeth when I saw the face of the unwelcome guest who had broken through my deep thoughts and approached me.

President Baek Hanseong.

It was him.

And if the President was here instead of at the Blue House, then everything that had happened was real.

"Ah…"

"Hunter Jin Taekyung?"

What more was there to say? I felt hollow.

Instead of answering, I sank back into the bed from where I'd half risen.

He pulled a chair close and spoke with concern.

"You still seem unwell. The doctor will be here soon, so please wait just a moment…"

I didn't need a doctor or a Healer. Perhaps because I had gotten such deep rest, my body had completely recovered. My physical condition was not what mattered right now.

"How long… how long has it been?"

"Hmm."

President Baek Hanseong paused at the sound of my hoarse voice, then held out the newspaper in his hand.

"This morning's paper. It'll be quicker if you see for yourself."

I took it and checked the date first.

Two days had passed since the day I remembered. An enormous photograph of my face covered the front page, accompanied by a bold headline.

The Truth of That Day, Sullied by Countless Misunderstandings. The Hero Who Has Not Awakened.

I could tell from the headline alone. It told me how much the media had talked about me and about what had happened that day over the past two days.

But I felt neither irritation nor anger. Only a heavy, numbing sadness.

So it was true. It really was true.

Butler Kim—Kim Hwajong—was dead.

Weighed down by that reality, I stared blankly out the window. President Baek Hanseong spoke carefully.

"One news outlet acted rashly and broke the agreed guidelines, so public opinion was against you at first… Fortunately, the misunderstandings about this incident have been cleared up. Go Se-won stepped forward at just the right time. Thanks to him, matters were resolved sooner than we expected."

"Go Se-won?"

I turned from the window at the unexpected name. President Baek Hanseong met my eyes and nodded.

"Yes, the same Go Se-won you know. The closest aide who served as Head of Security for the Vice Guild Master—no, for the late Go Jun."

"…"

"He turned himself in first. The executives from Go Jun's faction who resisted until the end had already been subdued by him. His testimony was very conclusive as well."

When I'd spared him, I hadn't expected this kind of help.

I looked at the newspaper again. My face wasn't the only one on the front page.

Halfway down was a photograph of Go Se-won before a crowd of cameras and microphones, wearing his usual calm expression. Beside it was his testimony that Go Jun had caused the two monster waves two days earlier.

"It was decisive testimony. And furthermore…"

President Baek Hanseong frowned before continuing.

"It also corroborated the evidence concerning Go Jun's body, which had been discovered earlier."

Go Jun had died as a hideous blend of human and monster. His corpse alone was clear physical evidence.

President Baek Hanseong shuddered, as though he had seen the scene with his own eyes, and continued.

"Go Se-won played a very important role. Thanks to him, Hunter Jin Taekyung was able to clear himself of most of the charges."

I nodded, feeling nothing.

Charges. Judgment under the law. Words everyone feared, but right now they meant little to me.

"I see."

"Yes. He's being held in a special detention center for now… but he's asked to see you as soon as possible. He says he has a debt to repay."

A debt to repay.

I repeated the words to myself and shook my head.

I had no objection to seeing Go Se-won, but something more important was on my mind.

Butler Kim. And Team Leader Choi.

Had the old butler's funeral begun? Had Team Leader Choi regained consciousness?

That was what I wanted to know most.

I was just about to part my dry lips when the door flew open without a knock.

A blond foreigner ignored President Baek Hanseong entirely and spoke with a grave expression.

"That human. No—he's awake."

"…!"

Chapter 597

The path I had walked until now had been strewn with countless deaths and screams.

But I could say with certainty that I had never felt grief as quiet and suffocating as this.

Tap. Tap-tap.

Beyond the silence, wind and rain battered the window.

We had said everything we needed to say long ago, yet silence still filled the room where only the two of us remained.

Team Leader Choi had been staring out the window with his head turned away. At last, he spoke.

“I think I was seven when Butler Kim came to me.”

His memories of those early years had grown hazy. More than twenty years had passed since then.

The child who had suddenly lost his parents had grown into a young man, and frost had settled in the butler’s hair.

“I can barely remember my parents’ voices anymore, but every memory I have with him is vivid.”

When his parents died and even his only maternal grandfather disappeared, Butler Kim had always been there beside him.

“One day, I realized how much he had devoted to me. More than I could ever measure. But…”

His voice trailed off, and he turned toward me.

Perhaps it was because he had spent so long looking out at the rain, but his eyes were drenched when they met mine.

“Now I can’t give anything back. Not ever.”

Tap. Tap-tap.

I had never seen him like this.

A tear rolled down his cheek as he spoke in a heavy, subdued voice. It fell onto the snow-white blanket.

No. That was the wind and rain striking the window. For now, I chose to believe it was.

“Mr. Jin.”

I nodded instead of answering.

Team Leader Choi had spent more time with Butler Kim than anyone. The grief I’d felt earlier was nothing beside what he must be feeling now.

He’d lost family.

To Team Leader Choi, Kim Hwajong hadn't been a butler. He had been family—the one person who stayed beside a child left alone, the only person that child could lean on.

He could blame me for failing to save him. He could grab me by the collar and curse me out.

Right now, that would be fine. Better to let it all spill out than keep forcing it down. I didn't want Team Leader Choi drowning in everything he was holding back.

Then his next words caught me off guard.

"Thank you."

"…!"

"For watching over his final moments. For doing what I couldn't… I sincerely thank you."

I couldn't speak. I wanted to answer, but something rising inside me had locked my throat shut.

I stared at Team Leader Choi in silence for a long time before finally forcing out my voice.

"Team Leader Choi."

Before I could say more, he shook his head slightly.

"I'm all right. Really."

It was an obvious lie. I knew it was, and I had no choice but to let him tell it.

I pressed my lips together. Team Leader Choi gave me a faint smile.

"I'm embarrassed you had to see me like this. Would you mind giving me some time alone?"

What could I say to him now? I had neither the words nor the right.

Team Leader Choi needed time. Time to accept the death of someone who had been as close as blood. Time to find the courage to face his body.

"Get some rest, then. There are people standing by, so call if you need anything."

I tried to sound cheerful as I got up and headed for the door. But when I put my hand on the doorknob, I thought of one last thing I wanted to tell him.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes?"

"It's all right to lose your balance sometimes. You can cry out loud. No one will hear you. Except for him."

"…!"

"I'll be going now."

My back was already turned, so I couldn't see his expression or know how my words had struck him.

I was glad I couldn't.

Click.

As I stepped out and pulled the door shut, I heard a faint sob through the narrowing gap.

It was the quietest, saddest sob I had ever heard. The sound of a man who had never wavered, no matter what happened, finally breaking down.

"Taekyung, how's Team Leader Choi—"

I wasn't the only one who could hear him.

Im Kkeokjeong had started to ask with a worried look on his face, but he fell silent. So did the other two waiting with him in the hall.

"Ah, I'm tired. I need some coffee."

Song Song stretched and walked away quickly. The Skeleton King caught my eye, scratched his chin, and said, "This body could use some coffee too. I haven't been sleeping lately. I feel like I might collapse…"

"Huh? Oh. Yeah, me too."

Im Kkeokjeong was one thing, but an undead monster claiming he was sleepy and needed coffee? I let out a quiet laugh at the ridiculous excuse and patted the Skeleton King's shoulder.

"Make me a cup too."

"You wretched human. Have you no hands? No feet?"

"I have a spear."

The Skeleton King fell silent for a moment at my answer, then narrowed his eyes.

"…Black?"

"Mix."[2699]

"You don't even know what good coffee tastes like. I'll make it for you this once. Just this once."

By the time Im Kkeokjeong had left the hallway after the Skeleton King, who continued grumbling curses under his breath, the sound of dress shoes echoed from the distance.

Step. Step.

Three men in black suits came into view.

Their steady breathing and measured steps told me they were well-trained Peak masters—or rather, A-rank Hunters.

But the fact that they had entered this mansion at all meant they were no ordinary Hunters. They belonged to an organization very different from a Guild.

"Pleased to meet you, Hunter Jin Taekyung."

Instead of answering, I looked at them. More precisely, at their tie pins.

Each black-and-gold badge bore a rose of Sharon[2700] and tiny engraved letters.

President's Security Service

[2699] Korean coffee mix is instant coffee packaged with sugar and powdered creamer.

[2700] The rose of Sharon is South Korea's national flower and appears on government insignia.

It was clear whose orders they were following.

I gave a small nod. “President Baek Hanseong is looking for me?”

“No, sir,” the officer in front replied in a stiff, military tone. “His Excellency left thirty minutes ago. He asked for your understanding. Affairs of state required him to leave without saying goodbye.”

He must have gone while I was in Team Leader Choi’s room. I understood his situation well enough. I had no complaints.

“There’s nothing to apologize for. I’m sure I’ve made him ten times busier than usual.”

“…”

“…Twenty times?”

“Ahem.”

“Cough.”

They couldn’t bring themselves to say it, but the repeated throat-clearing told me he was busy as hell.

I hadn’t checked what was happening outside yet. Still, the events of two days ago must have turned not just Korea but the whole world upside down.

No wonder.

Several monster waves in a single day were unprecedented. Learning that they had been deliberately caused—and that Ares Guild’s Vice Guild Master was behind it all—would hit harder than a nuclear bomb.

Even I, who knew little about the situation, couldn’t easily guess how large and far-reaching the aftermath of this incident would be.

“So did you stay just to give me that message?”

“Not exactly.”

“Then…”

As my voice trailed off, all three bowed politely.

“By order of His Excellency the President, we have been assigned to provide temporary security for Hunter Jin Taekyung and your family. Although we have been described as a surveillance detail on the surface, we ask that you put yourself at ease.”

“A surveillance detail?”

“This will only continue until the current situation has settled down. It has only been two days, after all, and under the current circumstances, Hunter Jin Taekyung remains a suspect who has been booked without detention.”

Booked without detention. Like *surveillance detail*, it didn’t have a pleasant ring to it.

I’d heard the phrase since I was a kid. Whenever a high-ranking politician or

chaebol[2701] chairman got into trouble, it seemed to turn up on the news.

At least I haven't been detained.

Being booked without detention meant that the suspect or defendant's physical freedom was guaranteed, while the case itself had been formally registered with the judicial authorities.

"What are the charges?"

"There are extenuating circumstances for the other matters, but… for now, the main issue is the injuries you inflicted."

The officer who seemed to be in charge added, looking at me with a mixture of respect and fear, "As you know, more than five hundred people sustained injuries, major or minor, at your hands."

"Oh."

"Of course, you needn't worry too much. Given public opinion at home and abroad, as well as the circumstances of the incident, there's a strong possibility your actions will be recognized as self-defense."

I had expected some kind of punishment, but my situation was far better than I'd thought.

Once the truth came out, people in Korea and overseas had begun to accept that my actions were justified. Meanwhile, the late Go Jun had become a fucking bastard in the eyes of the entire world.

That was the gist of it.

I thought I might be going straight to prison.

Right before I went to Ares Guild Headquarters, I'd said I was leaving Peace Guild in case my actions brought trouble down on them. Things had turned out so well that the decision almost seemed pointless.

Of course, I couldn't really call any of this good. It had begun with Kim Hwajong's death.

And…

Things probably settled down this fast because someone gave them solid testimony.

I thought back to my conversation with President Baek Hanseong an hour or so earlier, and to the photograph of a middle-aged man who had looked composed before a crowd of cameras and microphones.

Go Se-won.

The President had told me Go Se-won was being held in a special detention center and wanted to see me. He said he had a debt to repay.

A debt to repay. What could he mean?

We'd met only briefly, but Go Se-won didn't strike me as someone who would ask for a meeting just to exchange pleasantries.

[2701] A *chaebol* is a large, usually family-controlled South Korean business conglomerate.

Even if I was wrong, I needed to talk to him at least once. He had given up everything to reveal the truth.

The countless crimes Go Se-won must have committed while rising to become Head of Security could never be washed away, but it was also an undeniable fact that I owed him a debt.

While I stood there thinking, the Skeleton King came swaggering down the hall.

“I brought your coffee. Drink it.”

I looked at the steaming cup of instant coffee mix. Then I made up my mind.

“Don’t want it.”

“…You shitty hu—bastard.”

Leaving him growling behind me, I turned to the officers.

“Let’s go. Show me the way.”

“Pardon?”

“Go Se-won. He’s being held in a special detention center, right?”

The officers looked bewildered for a moment, then nodded.

Chapter 598

There is always a reason behind things described as *special*.

The special detention center where Go Se-won was being held was no exception.

“Stop. We need to verify your identities.”

The soldier’s voice was stiff, his sharp eyes visible behind dark sunglasses. He wore a bulletproof vest and carried an automatic rifle.

The Blue House[2702] security officer in the driver’s seat held out a thin card.

“The warden should have received a call already.”

“I’m sorry, but everyone goes through the same procedure here.”

The soldier didn’t budge. Only after checking us with a magic detector to make sure no one was disguised did he raise the barrier. A little later, I got my first glimpse of the detention center I’d heard so much about.

Around a hundred soldiers stood guard, armed to the teeth. Hunters disguised as soldiers were hidden among them.

As if that weren’t enough, heavy weapons were positioned throughout the facility, along with concealed magic traps.

Most people wouldn’t be able to walk out of here in one piece.

This place held people who hadn’t yet received a verdict. Even so, security was far tighter than at a prison reserved for serious criminals.

One look at the warden waiting outside the main building told me why.

“Ho-ho. I’ve been waiting for you.”

He had the warm, genial face of an old man from a fried-chicken restaurant. The energy he gave off was anything but warm.

A former A-rank Hunter with an impressive record, the warden greeted me with a friendly attitude.

“When I first heard the news about you, I felt so relieved. This isn’t something I should say as the warden, but… honestly, every time I see the bastards in here, I feel like smashing their heads in with a mace. Isn’t that why I’ve gone bald from holding myself back?”

“…Oh. I see.”

His confession caught me so off guard that I could only give an awkward reply. Then I looked at his gleaming head and muttered, “You must have held back a lot.”

“What else could I do? Though when I really can’t stand it, I do give one of them a beating now and then. Only the worst ones, of course.”

“Pardon?”

[2702] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea’s president.

"Give them a cup of potion and plenty of healing, and they're good as new. What are they going to do? There's no evidence. None."

"…"

"Criminal bastards need a beating. Especially the ones in here."

The Blue House[2703] security officers wore expressions that seemed to ask whether they should report this to the President, and I began to worry about whether one particular person was still alive.

"Is Go Se-won still alive?"

"Ah, that fellow."

The warden laughed heartily.

"Of course. He's perfectly fine. On his first day, I thought he might cause a major incident, but… he does as he's told, and from what I hear from the prosecutors' office, he's been giving his statement without any trouble. I had the visitation room cleared out for you. Follow me."

The security officers and I followed him inside.

The corridors were dark and cold. Alloy doors stood in rows like cages where iron bars would normally have been. Small hologram projectors outside each door showed every movement and expression of the people inside.

I'd heard about this place, but I'd never seen it for myself.

What made the special detention center special was that everyone held here was Awakened.

If an Awakened person committed a crime, they were brought here immediately, regardless of the charge. They might not have been convicted yet, but that didn't spare them the tight security or constant surveillance.

They're Awakened, after all.

Even an F-grade Awakened could easily subdue two or three grown men.

If they were higher-ranked and had obtained a Hunter license through formal training, that went without saying.

"They're awaiting verdicts, sure, but most of them are obviously guilty. You never know what they might try. We get two or three escape attempts every year without fail. Once they're convicted and transferred to a special prison, they won't have another chance. That place is hell."

As he explained while crossing the corridor, the warden pointed toward three or four metal doors that looked particularly thick and sturdy.

"We're watching the bastards who came in this time particularly closely. They've got nothing left to lose, and they've been pretty rough."

[2703] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea's president.

I checked the holograms to see who he meant. They were the Ares Guild executives I'd briefly glimpsed on the top floor. Go Se-won and the other Ares Guild members must have subdued them and sent them here.

They lay wrapped in mana suppressors from head to toe like mummies. I studied them, then made a heartfelt request.

"Please beat the shit out of them—good and proper."

"I was planning to. I've already greased up the mace I used back in my active days."

"You really do have everything planned, Warden."

The warden smiled, pleased by my compliment, then asked, "Ah, but what's going to happen to you, Hunter Jin Taekyung? I hope things work out for you, but the law is a complicated thing."

"Who knows? I still have no idea."

"It would be nice if you came here. I'd take good care of you."

"…Oh. Right."

Why was I suddenly picturing a mace glistening with grease?

While that unpleasant image occupied my mind, the long, twisting corridor came to an end at a large door.

Once we had finished every procedure at the security checkpoint, the warden explained, "You'll meet with him alone, Mr. Jin Taekyung. By special request from above, there won't be a guard in the room or a time limit. But everything inside will be recorded on audio and video, so please bear that in mind."

Given Go Se-won's situation, that much was only natural. I nodded, and the door opened.

Click.

Cold air met me as it swung inward. The room looked like one of the prosecutors' interrogation rooms I'd seen in movies, and a familiar face was waiting inside.

"You came. Sooner than I expected."

Go Se-won.

He looked noticeably more haggard than he had two days ago. Once the door closed, he pointed to a chair.

"Don't just stand there. Sit down. My neck hurts from looking up at you."

Clank.

Heavy metal rattled whenever he moved. He noticed me looking at the chains linking his neck, arms, and legs, and shrugged.

"Mana suppressor. It's uncomfortable, but all things considered, they're treating me well."

I pulled out a chair and sat.

“I suppose so. On the way here, I saw your friends looking about ready to move into a pyramid.”

“Who? Executive Director Park? Managing Director Lee? Or…”

“Probably both. I couldn’t tell you which was which.”

“Fair enough. Neither of them is my friend anyway.”

Even now, he was as calm as ever. I watched him for a moment, then asked, “Should I thank you?”

The question came out of nowhere, but Go Se-won knew what I meant. He gave a quiet laugh.

“I’d been thinking about doing it for a long time. I just needed a reason.”

“Any regrets?”

“Not a single one.”

His face was haggard, but his eyes were clearer than ever. Maybe that was why I’d spared him.

When everyone else in Ares Guild had looked at me with anger and fear, he’d kept that clear, steady gaze. Even when death was right in front of him.

“You must have lost a lot over this.”

“I lost as much as I gained. I’ve only gone back to the way I was then—a war orphan who had nothing. More importantly, I protected my precious family. I should be satisfied with that.”

Everyone gets a chance to change. For Go Se-won, his family had probably been the reason. Maybe that last phone call, arriving when death was almost upon him, had led him to this choice.

“I saw the photo on your phone. Your son’s cute. Looks like a tough kid, too. He’s already got a solid build. He’d be perfect as a tank when he grows up.”

“She’s my daughter.”

“Ah…”

They do say the eldest daughter takes after her father.

When I fell silent after accidentally assigning someone’s daughter to the tank class, Go Se-won let out a small sigh.

“I called you because I thought you might be able to help me, but you make me lose the desire to ask.”

“…”

“Well, never mind. In any case, the fact that you came to see me means you’ve already heard about it, right?”

Relieved that he’d changed the subject, I nodded.

“What did they tell you?”

“That you had a debt to repay me. I didn’t hear anything more specific.”

“Then you heard right. Passing it along through someone else didn’t sit right with me, so I kept quiet.”

Didn’t sit right with him?

Go Se-won was cooperating with every investigation and interrogation. He was laying out even his own wrongdoings without holding anything back, almost like a confession.

Yet there was something he hadn’t told them.

I knew there was more to it.

Just as I sensed that something serious was coming, he began fiddling with his earlobe.

It wasn’t a signal we’d agreed on, but I had no trouble understanding it.

Fwoosh.

Internal energy rose from my dantian and surrounded the visitation room. Sound was cut off in an instant.

Go Se-won noticed despite the mana suppressor. He pretended to rub the corner of his mouth and whispered, “Area A isn’t the only secret area hidden in the Guild headquarters.”

“What?”

“Search Area A carefully. There’s another secret area inside it.”

Another hidden space.

I blinked at him, then hurriedly asked, “Where? What’s the exact location?”

But contrary to my expectations, the answer that came back was low and brief.

“I don’t know.”

“What?”

“If I knew, I’d tell you. But only Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong and Go Jun could enter. I don’t know where it is or how to get in. I only learned it existed shortly after I became Head of Security.”

Go Se-won had once been counted among Go Jun’s closest aides. Even he knew only that the second secret area existed, and nothing more.

“Then maybe…”

“Of course, I don’t know what’s inside or what they do there. That’s all I know.”

He cut me off sharply, then continued.

“The government investigation team must be searching Area A from top to bottom by now, but they probably haven’t noticed it yet.”

“Why?”

“If they had, they would have asked me about it before anything else.”

“…!”

“So, Jin Taekyung. Find it. I don’t know what secrets it holds, but…”

I was about to ask another question when the heavy door opened with a metallic clang. The warden and the Blue House[2704] security officers looked at us suspiciously.

“We couldn’t hear anything. Is there a problem?”

Go Se-won answered calmly.

“The visit is over.”

[2704] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea’s president.

Chapter 599

All the way back to the estate after my visit, I sensed a subtle change in the air.

Their glances and movements looked natural enough, no doubt thanks to rigorous training. But they couldn't escape my senses.

They definitely suspect something.

The A-rank Hunters of the President's Security Service.

They'd said they were there to provide temporary protection for my family and me, but I wasn't naive enough to take their word for it.

If they notice even the slightest thing out of place, they'll report it straight up the chain.

They weren't Peace Guild members or ordinary Hunters. They were government employees whose direct superior was one person: the President.

President Baek Hanseong might already have received a report about today's visit —my private meeting with Go Se-won, and the minute or two when no one had been able to hear what we said.

What should I do?

I sank into thought as I stared at the specially treated window that prevented anyone from seeing inside the vehicle.

Go Se-won had told me there was another secret area. Now I had to decide when to reveal that information, and to whom.

I didn't have to think for long.

I can't do anything right now anyway.

Only two days had passed since that day. The world was still in turmoil, and people had yet to recover from their grief and shock.

Even Team Leader Choi, who needed to know more than anyone, was no exception.

So I had to keep my mouth shut at least until Kim Hwajong's funeral was over.

It wasn't only for Team Leader Choi's sake. I needed time to sort things out myself.

"Phew."

At my quiet sigh, the security officer in the driver's seat glanced at me in the rearview mirror.

"Is something bothering you?"

"No. It's nothing."

I sank deeper into the seat as I lied.

The truth was, I was uncomfortable. Everything around me made me uncomfortable.

Silently repeating the truth I hadn't voiced, I looked out at the world beyond the window.

The scenery slipped past, and time passed just as quickly.

January 19.

A week had passed since the day that came to be known as the January 19 Incident,[2705] and the world was still in an uproar.

The flames that had erupted that day refused to die down easily. No—no one could control them as they continued to burn.

The media in Korea and around the world threw firewood and oil onto the flames, while public opinion fanned the growing blaze.

> **January 19. The day darkness descended upon Korea.**
>
> **Two artificially induced monster waves. UN Secretary-General: “An international crime that can never be forgiven.”**
>
> **The Vatican: “He is not human, but Satan. Another Demon King.”**
>
> **Official statement from Ares Guild: “Go Jun’s atrocities deserve condemnation. We bow our heads and apologize to the people.”**
>
> **Families of the January 19 Incident’s victims prepare a massive lawsuit against Ares Guild and the government.**
>
> **Go Se-won’s continuing revelations: “Ares is rotten.”**

The ones taking the greatest beating were, of course, Go Jun and Ares Guild.

Go Se-won had briefly been second-in-command within the Guild, and he gave detailed testimony about every act of corruption and every crime he knew of.

As secrets that no one had known—or that people had known and kept quiet about—came to light, the world was turned upside down once again.

The prosecutors’ office issued countless search and arrest warrants. Several overseas branch directors sensed what was coming and even tried to flee.

> **└ Did you see the news? I heard the Chinese branch director got caught over there while trying to flee.**
>
> **└ Yeah, saw it. A wanted notice went out right away, and the Public Security Armed Forces Department caught him.**
>
> **└ Of all people, he had to get caught by those Chinks. Fucking idiot. What a disgrace to the country.**

[2705] The Korean name for the January 19 Incident also reads as “119 Incident.” In Korea, 119 is the emergency telephone number for fire and ambulance services.

> **└ ??? The Public Security Armed Forces Department are good Chinks, so don't insult them. Don't you know they teamed up with Lord Fuck during the Small Cataclysm and smashed an Arch Lich's head in?**
>
> **└ What's a good Chink?**
>
> **└ A good Chink.**
>
> **└ The King Public Security Armed Forces Department deserves credit. The guy who caught the Chinese branch director is Xiao Shen, the youngest ever head of the department. He's a die-hard Jin Taekyung fan.**
>
> **└ For real?**
>
> **└ In interviews he kept saying "Big Brother Taekyung" and "Big Brother Lord Fuck." Turns out the Chinese branch director damaged local cultural relics too, so the Ministry of Foreign Affairs is pissed.**
>
> **└ ?? Was this asshole a Red Guard[2706] in his past life?**
>
> **└ Maybe it's revenge for the Northeast Project.[2707] Those mainlanders still call hanbok hanfu.[2708]**
>
> **└ Winnie the Pooh[2709] died ages ago, but hanfu's still alive and kicking…**

It was the first—and worst—crisis Ares Guild had faced since its founding.

Nearly half the Guild's executives were summoned by the prosecutors' office. Even those who had committed no apparent crimes or acts of corruption had to be questioned as witnesses.

In stark contrast, public opinion toward Jin Taekyung and the Peace Guild, who had played a greater role than anyone in the January 19 Incident, was overwhelmingly favorable.

> **Summary of Lord Fuck's achievements.jpg**
>
> **I was at the scene during the Pyeongchang monster wave. I'm grateful to the fifteen Peace Guild Hunters, including the late Guild Master Kim Hwajong. May the deceased rest in peace.**
>
> **Honestly, what crime did Jin Taekyung commit? (Long post warning)**
>
> **The Blue House national petition has surpassed ten million signatures.**

An enormous number of posts defending Jin flooded the internet every day.

[2706] Red Guards were youth groups mobilized during China's Cultural Revolution.

[2707] The Northeast Project was a Chinese historical research program disputed in Korea for treating ancient kingdoms associated with Korean history as part of Chinese history.

[2708] Hanbok is traditional Korean clothing; hanfu is traditional Han Chinese clothing. The comment alludes to disputes over claims about the origins of Korean dress.

[2709] Winnie the Pooh has been used online to satirize Chinese leader Xi Jinping, and references to the character have faced censorship in China.

They passionately insisted on Jin Taekyung's innocence, submitted national petitions, and even held protests condemning the media outlets that had recklessly targeted Jin during the earliest days, before the truth had come to light.

Even so, some voices stubbornly continued to criticize him.

> **Lee Kanghee, chief editorial writer at Patriotic Daily: "Jin Taekyung is nothing more than a lawless thug. The matter of Go Jun should have been left to the law…"**

The statement by one famous journalist won a considerable amount of support, but its significance quickly faded once the meaning of the Code Red issued against Jin Taekyung by Ares Guild—and the exact casualties from the January 19 Incident—came under scrutiny.

> **538 casualties in a fierce battle. Yet only twenty people died…**
>
> **The identities of the dead finally revealed: the late Go Jun and his security team.**
>
> **Go Se-won: "Go Jun's security team were loyal hunting dogs and fanatics. The Busan monster wave was also carried out by a security-team member on Go Jun's orders."**
>
> **Testimony from a victim at the scene: "Jin Taekyung knocked down everyone who blocked his path, but he never attacked the healers."**
>
> **The chivalry of a modern knight shines amid a bloody battle.**
>
> **Murders in London, United Kingdom. Ten security-team members flee after murdering the family of Ares Guild European Branch Director Song Cheonwoo, whom they had held captive. Interpol issues wanted notices…**
>
> **Lee Kanghee, chief editorial writer at Patriotic Daily: Why did he criticize Jin Taekyung? Where did the hundreds of billions of won[2710] in real estate held under borrowed names come from? Prosecutors begin an investigation.**

As more truths emerged, the voices criticizing Jin Taekyung faltered. Meanwhile, statements from famous figures who had firmly supported him from the start resurfaced.

[2710] Hundreds of billions of won is roughly 100–900 billion won, or about $71–640 million and €65–580 million.

> **Xiao Yang, Chairman of China: “We have not forgotten what happened in Sichuan. Sir Jin is a Great Hero, and he acts only according to justice.”**
>
> **Grand Mage Magic Johnson of the United States: “Jin is a hero, and the Korean media are trash. The truth will come out soon, so Kanghee Lee, who wasted paper on his stupid letters, should prostrate himself before my thick, enormous magic wand.”**
>
> **Prince Felix of the United Kingdom: “Jin was not born of noble blood, yet he proved his nobility himself. Unfortunately, those who insult him appear to possess lowly character. Come and kiss the back of my hand.”**
>
> **Japanese Prime Minister Shinjiro Koizumi: “I think the Korean media should reflect on insulting Mr. Jin, and although they are reflecting, I think they should reflect on the fact that they are not failing to show that they are reflecting.”**
>
> **Former U.S. President Joseph Biden: “He is a good young man. I met him in person not long ago, and he was calm and kind.” When a reporter asked when they had met, he thought for a moment before adding, “I think I confused him with someone else.”**

The world remained chaotic, and people could barely keep up with each day’s news.

In a public apology, President Baek Hanseong promised that nothing like this would ever happen again.

At the same time, under the slogan of cleansing society, he set his sights on the massive Guilds that had grown too powerful to touch.

Prominent figures and heads of state around the world continued to defend the Peace Guild.

Go Jun had committed crimes too horrifying to imagine, and Ares Guild was riddled with corruption. Even its former Vice Guild Master, Lee Jungryong, could not escape condemnation.

Yet among all the truths coming to light, one question remained unanswered.

Why? Why, even now, had Cheon Taemin himself not appeared?

It was the question everyone carried, and at the same time, a truth no one could uncover.

The whereabouts of Cheon Taemin, the immortal hero who had vanished without warning one day, remained shrouded in mystery.

He had not appeared when an Arch Lich emerged in China several months earlier and caused astronomical damage. Nor had he appeared at the national funeral of Lee Jungryong, who had been practically his sworn brother.

Not even when Jin Taekyung reduced the headquarters of Ares Guild—the Guild Cheon Taemin himself led—to ruins…

Cheon Taemin never showed himself. The questions people had about his incomprehensible seclusion swelled like a snowball rolling downhill.

And while the chaos and uncertainty had yet to subside, a massive national funeral was held for the victims of the January 19 Incident.

Korea, usually so noisy, was quiet that day.

The government declared a temporary public holiday. Roads that should have been packed with cars were empty, and the news reported in solemn tones that nearly thirty million people had gathered at locations across the country to mourn.

And… I was here.

At the place where those who had served with honor and devotion were laid to rest.

The National Cemetery.

Step.

Perhaps spring was slowly approaching, because the grass at the end of January was green and full of life.

A breeze brushed my face, and the sunlight was warm.

It was a beautiful day. A day to send someone off, and to remember them again.

> **January 19. Remembering them.**

I looked up from the short phrase engraved at the bottom.

Dazzling sunlight stung my eyes above the tall memorial. Among the names of more than two thousand victims carved into its surface, I found one I knew.

> **The late Kim Hwajong**

I was suddenly glad the weather was so fine.

He had shivered in the cold until the moment he died. On a warm day like this, with countless people there to pay their respects, I thought he could finally rest.

It must be warm now. Isn’t that right, Butler Kim?

His ashes would be buried somewhere other than this memorial, but I believed part of his spirit remained here too.

Just as I offered Kim Hwajong a question that could never reach him, a voice spoke.

“Butler Kim will rest peacefully.”

Team Leader Choi gazed at the memorial with sorrow in his eyes, then added, “But we’ll be even busier from now on.”

I nodded.

It was time to tell him what I had kept hidden.

Chapter 600

The grief of losing someone precious never disappears. Time only wears it down, little by little, until it grows faint.

In that sense, the past week had been exactly what Team Leader Choi needed to gather himself.

“He’ll rest peacefully. Butler Kim will. But we’ll be even busier from now on, won’t we?”

Those quiet words told me he was ready.

Ready to rise while keeping the person who had left us in his heart. Ready to start walking forward again.

So now I could tell him.

“I met Go Se-won a week ago.”

Team Leader Choi looked at me.

“Go Se-won… Ares Guild’s Head of Security?”

“Yes. Go Jun’s closest aide.”

At the mention of Go Jun, Team Leader Choi’s eyebrows twitched. He quickly steadied his expression and answered calmly.

“Please continue.”

“He asked to see me. Said he had a debt to repay.”

“A debt? Given what he’s done since, I doubt he only wanted to thank you.”

Team Leader Choi had never met Go Se-won, but he’d guessed right.

I nodded and told him everything I remembered about that day: our private meeting at the special detention center, and the existence of another secret area, which Go Se-won had told only me about.

“He didn’t know exactly where it was or what it was for. He said only Lee Jungryong and Go Jun could enter.”

When I finished, Team Leader Choi murmured, “I suspected as much… So it was true.”

“What?”

That wasn’t the reaction I’d expected. As I stared at him, eyes wide, he asked, “Does anyone else know about this, Mr. Jin?”

“Uh, I think Go Se-won and I are the only ones. We temporarily blocked the sound, and we covered our mouths while speaking.”

“I thought you said the President’s Security Service accompanied you.”

“They looked suspicious, but they haven’t asked me anything or reacted since. They might’ve reported it to President Baek Hanseong, though.”

“I see.”

I'd answered his questions. Now it was my turn.

"Did you already know, Team Leader Choi? It sounds like you did."

He nodded without trying to deny it.

"Someone told me."

"…So there weren't two of us. There were four. At this point, doesn't President Baek Hanseong know too?"

"I doubt it. Ares Guild's security is thorough, and very few people were allowed access to information about Area A. Besides…"

He added evenly, "There are three of us, not four."

"What?"

"The man who told me died recently. At one time, he was as close to Ares Guild's darkest secrets as Go Se-won."

As far as I knew, there couldn't have been many people like that. In fact, there had been so few since Ares Guild's founding that they could be counted on one hand.

And if he died recently…

A name flashed through my mind.

"Song Cheonwoo."

Team Leader Choi nodded. "The last time we met, inside the Gate, he told me several secrets he'd kept until then. I don't know whether his conscience finally troubled him or he just wanted to ease his own mind."

His reason didn't matter. What was done couldn't be undone. We needed to look for the traces it had left behind.

"Did Song Cheonwoo know where the other secret area was, or what it was for? That old man seems like he would."

"He didn't know where it was. He did know its purpose."

"What is it?"

That was what I'd wanted to know most. If Area A was the shell, the secret area inside it was the core.

What secret had Lee Jungryong and Go Jun—master and disciple—shared between them? What was hidden in a place that remained undiscovered even while Area A was being searched from top to bottom?

An astronomical amount of cash? S-rank Magic Gems siphoned off in secret? Or… a human experimentation lab?

Possibilities straight out of conspiracy theories and movies raced through my head.

Then Team Leader Choi spoke, and every thought vanished.

"My maternal grandfather."

"What?"

"The purpose of the other secret area is to hide my maternal grandfather's existence from the world."

"…!"

How much time had passed? Even as the wind blew and clouds drifted slowly overhead, I couldn't move for a long while.

This is insane.

I hadn't imagined this.

Cheon Taemin. *That* Cheon Taemin was in the secret area.

I felt as if the A-Gwi[2711] of Gyeongsang-do had smashed me in the back of the head with a sledgehammer. Frozen like a statue, I barely managed to speak.

"Um… You don't happen to have two maternal grandfathers, do you?"

"…"

"No, we need to be sure about this."

Team Leader Choi gave me a look that said *Are you an idiot?* before answering.

"Not as far as I know."

"…Huh."

Fuck. It really is him.

While I stood there speechless, Team Leader Choi hit me with another home run.

"I heard he lost consciousness more than twenty years ago. Lee Jungryong and Song Cheonwoo concealed that fact and kept it secret all this time."

"…He lost consciousness? Cheon Taemin? I mean… *the* Cheon Taemin?"

Humanity's immortal hero. The Slayer.

Cheon Taemin, the man who had defeated even the Demon King Asmodeus, was in a vegetative state.

That was harder to believe than Jinho hyung[2712] passing the civil service exam or Hyuk Mujin becoming the Murim Alliance Leader.

How is that possible?

Cheon Taemin held a place in this world much like the Martial God's in Murim. More than twenty years had passed since he withdrew from public life, yet no one had come close to matching him.

A flawless man of absolute power. That power was why he was called the immortal hero and held the authority he did.

And now I was supposed to believe he'd spent decades in a vegetative state—even in a world with cutting-edge medicine and magical treatments?

[2711] *A-gwi* is a ravenous ghost in Korean Buddhist folklore.

[2712] *Hyung* is a form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

Something stinks.

It seemed that thought had shown plainly on my face. Before I could say anything, Team Leader Choi shook his head.

“I don’t think Lee Jungryong or Song Cheonwoo did this to him.”

“Why not?”

“People tend to be honest when they’re facing death. Especially when their families are being held hostage.”

“…Right. Fair point.”

“The important thing is that my maternal grandfather is hidden in another secret area within Area A. And no one except those three knows about it. Not even the government, despite its thorough investigation of Area A.”

I thought of President Baek Hanseong, who had stood beside me throughout the national funeral. If anyone knew how to hide what they were thinking, it was a politician.

“Are you sure?”

“This isn’t a simple guess. It’s a certainty based on information. Several key insiders within the government investigation team sent to the site have already joined forces with us.”

“…!”

“So for now, at least, we don’t have to worry.”

Watching Team Leader Choi explain it so calmly, I had a sudden thought.

Maybe the past week had done more than get him back on his feet. Maybe it had set him running.

He’s already started.

After the life-or-death crisis in Sichuan and the grief he’d suffered in Pyeongchang, Team Leader Choi had grown tremendously. And I had a fair idea where his next long stride would take him.

“The investigation is expected to last at least a month. What would you do, Mr. Jin?”

“We’d have to stop the government’s investigation first. To secure that person while avoiding suspicion.”

“And the fastest way to stop it?”

“Put this whole mess to rest and become the legal owner of Area A as soon as possible.”

There was only one way to become Area A’s legal owner.

Team Leader Choi reached out and ran his hand over the memorial.

“I made Butler Kim a promise once.”

The impregnable fortress surrounding the royal castle had collapsed miserably, and the prince who had been stripped of his right to inherit the throne and sent into exile had finally returned after a long passage of time.

To reclaim the crown stolen from him long ago.

“I promised I would make Ares Guild mine. No matter what.”

His deeply sunken eyes gleamed.

Team Leader Choi stared at the name of the late Kim Hwajong, carved highest of all, then turned toward me.

“Will you help me?”

He didn’t need to ask. My answer had been settled the day I signed the contract he’d offered me.

“There’s still plenty of time left on my contract, so sure. But I’m not going to have to kill anyone else, am I?”

Team Leader Choi let out a quiet laugh at my deadpan question. It was the first time I’d seen him smile since he woke up.

He took out his phone.

“No. This time, you only need to be the stick.”

“The stick?”

“Yes. A little carrot and stick for those who can’t make up their minds.”

Beep. Beep. Beep. Click.

Someone picked up after the third ring. Team Leader Choi addressed them in a flat voice.

“Hello, Vice President Park Daewon. This is Choi Minwoo.”

I’d heard that name often enough in the news lately to know who he was calling.

The most senior executive left at Ares Guild.

With Vice Guild Master Go Jun dead and most of the executives who held real power dragged in for questioning by the prosecutors’ office after Go Se-won’s revelations, he was the man who had inadvertently become Ares Guild’s acting head.

“Yes, I’m listening. Team Leader Choi Minwoo—no, Mr. Choi Minwoo.”

Park’s voice sounded grim through the phone. Team Leader Choi answered gently.

“You still haven’t made up your mind, it seems. You left after the national funeral without saying anything to me.”

“I, well… It’s just…”

“Six o’clock this evening.”

“What?”

“I’ll come to the headquarters myself. When I open the conference room door and walk in, I want all the executives—including you, Vice President Park—to be there.”

“P-please wait. I still need more time…”

“Six o’clock this evening. You still have three hours, so that should be plenty of time. Goodbye.”

Click.

What the hell was that?

I stared dumbfounded at Team Leader Choi as he hung up without hesitation. He spoke as though nothing unusual had happened.

“You heard the conversation, so I assume you have a rough idea of the situation. Let’s go.”

“Right now? Leaving everything else aside, you said there are still three hours.”

“I’m holding a press conference too.”

“…What?”

“It’s going to be a busy day. We’ve waited a long time. Once you draw your sword, you have to swing it like lightning.”

Chapter 601

Repairs were underway at Ares Guild headquarters.

Inside the conference room, the mood was grim.

Some thirty men and women sat around a massive round table, their somber eyes fixed on the man speaking.

"…And that is why I called this emergency meeting."

Vice President Park Daewon had barely finished when objections erupted from all sides.

"Well, well. They must think very little of us. And it's a brat who isn't even thirty."

"His intentions couldn't be more obvious. He means to swallow Ares whole."

"No, hyung[2713]. Why would you call an emergency meeting at the request of an outsider who has no authority? Even if you are the Vice President, this is going too far."

As the complaints came at him, Park wiped his half-bald forehead with a handkerchief.

Nearing sixty, he found the whole situation bewildering.

How on earth did it come to this?

He had distinguished himself in battle, but political infighting had never been his strength. Fortunately, he was the sort of man who made no enemies, and that had allowed him to keep his largely ceremonial position as Vice President.

Then, ten days ago, while taking a vacation ahead of his retirement, he had heard news he could hardly believe.

Ares Guild headquarters had been crushed by a single person, and Go Jun, the Vice Guild Master, had been murdered.

That can't be true.

For the first ten minutes, at least, that was what Park had thought.

But every bit of it had been true. The impregnable fortress they had spent some thirty years building had fallen, and its newly appointed City Lord had lost his head before he had even settled into office.

And the retainers who had narrowly escaped the prosecutors' office were voicing their grievances in unison.

"This is absurd! We don't have to listen to such nonsense."

"We created the name Ares, and we were the ones who protected it. What right does some outsider—some bloody brat who still doesn't know how the world works—have to interfere?"

"Vice President Park, this really isn't right!"

[2713] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"…"

Park Daewon silently took a long drink from his glass of water.

Everyone gathered here had spent at least ten years with Ares Guild; some had been with it for more than thirty. Most of those who held real power in the Guild had been summoned by the prosecutors' office, but the executives in this room were far from powerless.

…But we can't ignore him, either.

Park Daewon knew all about Choi Minwoo.

No, he couldn't not know. Cheon Taemin's private life and family relationships had been protected with the utmost care, but things were different for the few people classified as his close associates. Park, a founding member of the Guild, was one of them.

I first saw him at his doljabi[2714]. The funeral was the last time…wasn't it?

The child who had slowly faded from his memory had grown up and returned to reclaim what he had lost long ago.

Park had spent his life going along with whatever happened around him, but this troubled him. He knew it was only a shallow sense of guilt for turning away from Choi Minwoo when the boy had been shut out of the Guild entirely.

What should I do?

While Park Daewon was lost in thought, a short, powerful voice rang through the noisy conference room.

"I was going to see how far you'd take this, but it's getting more ridiculous by the minute. I can't listen to any more."

"…!"

"…!"

A chill silence fell over the conference room. Eyes widened, and every gaze turned toward the speaker.

"Managing Director Kim, what kind of outrageous statement was that?"

"Managing Director, my ass. Hey, Kim Gwangpil! What the hell are you talking about?"

The silence broke into angry shouts. Managing Director Kim shrugged his broad shoulders.

"Am I wrong? I called it ridiculous because it is. And Executive Director Baek, watch your language. I may be your junior, but I don't care to be spoken to like that."

"Just you wait, you traitorous bastard…"

Kim's thick eyebrows twitched.

[2714] *Doljabi* is a Korean first-birthday custom in which a child chooses from objects laid out before them. The choice is traditionally taken as a sign of the child's future.

"What did you call me?"

"A traitor, you bastard! If it weren't for traitors like you, we wouldn't be in this goddamn mess!"

"Wasn't it the people on Executive Director Baek's side who acted like animals? We can figure that out simply by seeing who's in the detention center right now."

"What?"

"You seemed awfully bothered that a few executives and I joined Jin Taekyung. But in the end, what kind of shit was the Vice Guild Master—no, what was that man Go Jun—up to? Or did you have a hand in it too, Executive Director Baek?"

"You—you bastard…!"

"Hey, Managing Director Kim! Watch your mouth!"

"You're the ones who need to watch your mouths!"

"Exactly!"

"How dare you!"

The room split into two factions, furious shouts flying back and forth. Then Park Daewon, who had remained silent, spoke up.

"Strictly speaking, he isn't an outsider."

The executives stopped short.

"What?"

"Vice President Park, what did you just…?"

"I'm talking about Choi Minwoo."

Park slowly looked around at the thirty-odd executives.

"Isn't he Guild Master Cheon Taemin's only maternal grandson?"

"…!"

"…!"

He had touched on the one thing they had all been avoiding, and the room fell silent. Kim Gwangpil's faction brightened at once. The faces of those who had spent the meeting complaining went ashen.

"B-but that's only a rumor, isn't it?"

"Th-that's right, hyung[2715]. No one's confirmed it."

Word of Choi Minwoo's identity had been spreading quietly since the Small Cataclysm. They weren't so much ignorant as pretending to be.

Park, at least, had no need to pretend.

"No. I'm certain. Unless my memory fails me, he is that person's maternal grandson. And…"

Before anyone could object, Park set his smartphone on the table.

"It seems he's decided to tell the world himself."

[2715] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“What do you mean…?”

“Argue with each other all you like, but you should have checked what was happening outside. Especially since you barred the secretaries you brought from coming in. Wouldn’t you agree?”

Several executives seemed to realize what he meant. They hurriedly pulled out their phones.

Within a minute, startled gasps sounded around the room. A reporter’s urgent voice played from dozens of speakers.

> “M-Mr. Choi Minwoo! Could you tell us your maternal grandfather’s full name once more?”

Another voice followed, filling the conference room.

> “The Cheon character, the Tae character, and the Min character. Cheon Taemin. He is my maternal grandfather.”

> “…!”

> “…!”

The ceaseless camera flashes and the surrounding murmur vanished in an instant, both at the press conference shown in the video and inside the conference room.

Everyone had suspected it. But hearing that suspicion confirmed and announced to the world had an impact none of them had imagined.

All the more so when it concerned the only blood relative of Cheon Taemin, a man about whom everything was shrouded in mystery.

At the same moment, everyone in the room understood.

He’s finally drawn his sword.

After more than twenty years in what had amounted to exile, the royal grandson had returned. At the perfect moment, he had drawn the sharpest blade he possessed to reclaim what he had lost by his own strength.

The question was where he would swing it—and at whom.

Gulp.

No one could bring themselves to speak easily. As time passed in an atmosphere where an invisible thread of tension had been pulled taut, the room filled with faint whispers.

Then—

Beep.

Every head turned at the faint electronic sound. It had come from the clock on the conference room wall.

The current time shone in red LEDs, like a warning.

PM 06:00

Six o'clock.

The time they had gathered for. The time someone was due to arrive.

Step. Step.

Everyone heard shoes crossing the hallway outside the door, and without realizing it, they reflexively rose from their seats.

And then…

Click.

The door opened smoothly, revealing two people.

"You're all here early."

"Oh, they fixed this place already. I think I broke it last time."

The occupying force had arrived: one polite, one rude, and neither to be avoided.

When I was little, my father used to tell me, "Son, once a man draws his sword, he has to cut at least a radish."

By that measure, Team Leader Choi was a man among men. He had come to cut up Ares Guild, not a radish.

"…"

Come to think of it, I had already cut it down once myself. But still.

"Nice to meet you. I'm Choi Minwoo."

Team Leader Choi gave a polite bow, and the Ares Guild executives standing around the table awkwardly returned it.

Some looked as if the world would end in three seconds. Others wore broad smiles. I recognized them: they were the executives from Song Cheonwoo's faction who had sided with me when I attacked headquarters.

One person was harder to read.

The elderly middle-aged man seated at the head of the table was Vice President Park Daewon.

"Welcome, Team Leader Choi Minwoo."

Team Leader Choi studied his conflicted expression, then nodded.

"I hope I'm not late. The press conference ran longer than I expected. I apologize for keeping you waiting."

Judging by their faces, they'd all watched the live broadcast. About half of them didn't seem to think they'd got their money's worth from the license fee.

"Not at all. Before we begin, please have a seat…"

"That won't be necessary."

Team Leader Choi gently stopped Park from offering him a place.

"This won't take long. And since the others still think of me as an outsider, I wouldn't want to make them uncomfortable by drawing it out."

"…Ahem."

Awkward coughs came from around the table. Team Leader Choi paid them no mind as he looked over the room.

"I see five empty seats. Where are the three advisers and the directors of the United States and France branches?"

A middle-aged man with a prickly appearance answered with an uncomfortable expression.

"You seem very interested in our people."

"I have a good memory, Executive Director Baek."

"…"

Baek fell silent. One of the executives who had sided with me ten days ago answered promptly.

"They didn't come."

"Something unavoidable must have kept them away. Is that right?"

"The three advisers cited illness. As I understand it, the two branch directors refused to attend."

"I specifically told them to attend. It seems my wishes weren't conveyed properly."

Team Leader Choi muttered this calmly, and Executive Director Baek spoke again.

"This isn't an official meeting. We gathered at an outsider's request. No one was obliged to attend, even if that outsider…"

After hesitating for a moment, he continued in a distinctly quieter voice.

"…is that person's maternal grandson."

"You're right."

Team Leader Choi nodded in agreement, then took a small note from inside his clothes and handed it over.

"What's this?"

"A prescription for the advisers who are ill. Ah, the other two branch directors will receive something other than a prescription."

I had a feeling the advisers who'd used illness as an excuse would recover the moment they saw that note. It listed the crimes they'd committed that hadn't come to light yet.

Baek read it and swallowed hard.

“Th-this…”

“You don’t look well yourself, Executive Director Baek. Would you like a prescription too?”

“N-no! What are you talking about? I’m fine!”

I stood with my arms crossed, watching the situation, and muttered.

“Wasn’t that ‘I’m fine’ a bit too casual?”

“I—I’m quite well.”

One Hundred and One Ways to Kill Without a Sound, by Jin Taekyung.

“I—I’m perfectly fine, sir.”

Hmm. The man could take a hint. I glanced at him as he stood there swallowing nervously, then turned to Team Leader Choi.

“Can’t we sit down and talk? My legs hurt.”

“Well, there isn’t really a suitable seat…”

I helpfully pointed toward the head of the table before he could finish.

“There. That one’s empty.”

“Oh, I see. But would it be all right for me to sit there?”

“Let’s put it to a vote. Majority rules. Anyone opposed? Hands?”

“…”

No one raised a hand.

Chapter 602

A whip could be an effective way to make someone do what you wanted. It could also make them resent you. Team Leader Choi knew exactly how to use the one in his hand.

“Director Hong.”

From his seat at the head of the table, Team Leader Choi called on one of the youngest executives. Hong answered, his face tense.

“Yes, yes.”

“I’ve heard a great deal about you, Director Hong. They say you’re exceptionally capable.”

“Oh, no. I’ve just been lucky…”

“Luck alone doesn’t make someone an Ares Guild executive. Especially not at your age. Wouldn’t you agree?”

“…”

Team Leader Choi’s tone and voice were gentle, but an unmistakable anxiety appeared on Director Hong’s face. And there was bound to be a reason why Team Leader Choi had singled out one person from among dozens of executives.

“I grew up overseas, so it was hard to fit in at first. But people live there too, after all. One by one, I made friends.”

Exiled or not, he was still the royal grandson. Team Leader Choi had lived a life worlds apart from that of an ordinary guy like me. His connections went further than I could imagine.

“Some of those friends get in touch now and then with news. I’ve heard some interesting things about you too, Director Hong.”

“…Have you?”

“Yes. Nothing but praise. The same goes for the rest of you, of course.”

Each time Team Leader Choi’s calm gaze moved, the executive who met it flinched as if burned. None of them was stupid enough to take his words at face value.

Leave water standing long enough and it rots.

Ares Guild was one of the largest organizations in the world. An executive position there came with astronomical wealth and prestige.

How many people at this table were clean as fresh water? They hadn’t avoided a summons from the prosecutors’ office because they were spotless. They were just clean enough to pass for third-grade water.

The sewage, and those with filth floating in them, were already having a reunion in the detention center.

“Are you feeling unwell? You’re breaking out in a cold sweat.”

Director Hong wiped his forehead. “Oh, no. It’s just a little hot.”

"There must be a problem with the temperature-control Magic. You should have it fixed."

Magic kept the conference room at a comfortable temperature, but half the executives were breathing as if they'd stepped into a steam room. They had all seen the whip tucked up Team Leader Choi's sleeve. He didn't have to swing it. A glimpse was enough to put pressure on them.

There was, of course, an exception.

"I can't listen to any more of this."

The speaker was a middle-aged man with irritable eyes and a sparse white beard. He tapped thick knuckles on the round table.

"Are you seriously threatening us?"

"You're Director Kim, in charge of the Asian region."

Team Leader Choi rubbed his chin. "Is that how it feels?"

"What if it did?"

"I won't deny it. It's true."

"What?"

"I said it's true. I'm threatening you, and I intend to make Ares Guild mine."

He added gently, "With everyone's consent, of course. Legally."

"A lizard thinks it can swallow a dinosaur."

Director Kim looked between Team Leader Choi and me and gave a short laugh.

"You two are young, and it shows. Do you think Ares Guild is a joke?"

I nodded, looking interested. "Hmm. A little?"

"…"

That seemed to leave him at a loss. After a brief silence, he went on.

"Headquarters fell. That doesn't mean the whole of Ares Guild is helpless. No matter how strong you are, do you think you can take on all of us?"

He had a point. Ares Guild had branches all over the world, and the forces at headquarters were only a fraction of its strength. Even I couldn't subdue them all on my own.

But…

"So what?"

At my question, bewilderment flashed across Director Kim's face.

"What?"

"What, asshole?"

"Asshole?"

"You fucking bastard, I ought to—"

"…Huh?"

What the hell is this guy doing? His face said it all.

I raised my fist. Director Kim instinctively edged his chair back and blinked.

"What… what is this?"

"What does it look like? I'm about to fuck you up."

"You're going to use force? Now? Here?"

"Should I use my brains instead? It's depressing enough how little I've got to work with."

"But… that would be illegal."

"Was it legal when I took Go Jun's head off ten days ago?"

"…!"

"Something will work out. I've already sent a few people to the grave. Who's going to complain if I add one more? Right?"

Team Leader Choi smacked his lips. "This is a different matter. Someone might complain."

"Things have been going pretty well for me lately, but even I couldn't stay out of prison, could I?"

"That's right. But given how favorable the public image and public opinion surrounding Mr. Jin Taekyung are at present, if things go well, you might be able to settle for a few years."

"Right. What if I was drunk?"

"Are you a genius? That would cut the sentence considerably."

"Come to think of it, I've been through so much lately that I might have diminished mental capacity."

"Oh, you could even aim for a suspended sentence."

What a wonderful country. Get drunk, claim diminished mental capacity, and they'd throw in a generous sentence reduction.

The man listening to our hopeful discussion had gone ashen.

"You… you lunatics."

"I thought you knew. You didn't know I was a lunatic?"

"…!"

"Then watch yourself. We're trying to do this the nice way. Why are you the only one making trouble?"

It was only talk, of course.

What mattered was how it sounded to him. I was the madman who had gone berserk, smashed up Ares Guild headquarters, and killed people without a thought for the consequences. Right now, even a joke from me would sound like a threat.

If the whip doesn't work, you need one hell of a strong whip.

The one man who had come close to openly dissenting pressed his lips together. Vice President Park Daewon, who had been watching quietly, spoke up.

"I understand what the two of you want. As for Team Leader Choi Minwoo returning to Ares Guild… I support it in my capacity as Vice President."

"V-Vice President."

"Why? Is there a problem?"

"Well, that…"

Startled voices came from around the table. But the tide had turned, and Team Leader Choi offered them the carrot he had prepared.

"If the rest of you accept Vice President Park Daewon's opinion, Ares Guild will stabilize quickly. The vacancies created by this incident will soon be filled as well."

"…What are you saying?"

"Whatever has happened up to now, I have no intention of discounting your abilities. Once things settle down, there will be major personnel changes."

I could practically see the rabbits' ears perk up as they recognized the carrot.

If Ares Guild changed hands, its existing executives had the most to lose. Take away that worry and promise them promotions instead, and things looked very different.

No reason to refuse.

Besides, Team Leader Choi had nothing to disqualify him. Quite the opposite. He was more than qualified, which was why he could speak with such quiet confidence.

"I'll put everything that has happened until now behind me. I'll quickly stabilize the Guild, restore its tarnished image, and use this incident as a stepping stone to make it grow even larger."

No one questioned him now. It wasn't only the carrot. They knew what Team Leader Choi could do.

In barely half a year, he had brought Peace Guild to where it stood today. I'd played a key role in that, sure. But without his eye for people, his ability to run an organization, and his political skill, there would be no Peace Guild as it was now.

And there was something else.

He's Cheon Taemin's only blood descendant.

Dynasties had vanished from this country long ago, but Cheon Taemin's name belonged to the realm of the divine.

The bloodline of the man who saved humanity carried its own power and nobility. No chaebol[2716] group, however wealthy, and no dynasty that had ever existed could claim to stand above Team Leader Choi.

And a title like that was bound to carry tremendous influence, especially within Ares Guild.

"Hmm."

[2716] *Chaebol* is a Korean term for a large, family-controlled business conglomerate.

Low groans rose from various parts of the conference room. They knew it too. Lee Jungryong and Go Jun had been nothing more than usurpers, while Team Leader Choi—with undeniable legitimacy and ability—was the one suited to become the new City Lord.

Scrape.

The sound of chairs broke the silence. More than ten executives stood. They had been in the same boat since ten days ago, and they bowed respectfully to Team Leader Choi without hesitation, as though they had been waiting for this moment.

"…!"

The tide was with us now. The others had seen the whip and the carrot. It was time to choose.

One by one, the watching executives rose.

Scrape. Scrape.

Amid the sounds of shifting chairs, I sent a Sound Transmission to the last two holdouts.

—Oh, for fuck's sake…

"…!"

"…!"

Executive Director Baek and Director Kim shuddered as though they'd been electrocuted. Then they got to their feet on trembling legs and bowed.

Only one executive remained seated.

Vice President Park Daewon.

Under the gazes of Team Leader Choi and me, he finally rose quietly from his seat. An aged voice slipped through his dry lips.

"Do you know I'll be retiring soon?"

Team Leader Choi calmly nodded, and Vice President Park Daewon muttered softly.

"Then this will be my last task."

"If you wish, I can arrange for you to stay longer."

"No. I'm sorry I failed to look after you all these years… and thank you for coming back."

Of everyone in the room, Park had been with Ares Guild the longest. That also meant he had turned away from Team Leader Choi the longest.

He looked at Team Leader Choi, conflicting emotions plain on his face, then bowed respectfully. His next words brought it all to an end.

"I'll convene an official board meeting, Young Master."

"…!"

A glint passed through Team Leader Choi's eyes.

Surrounded by some thirty retainers, he was already the City Lord in all but name.

Chapter 603

It's over.

Thud.

Baek Hanseong, the occupant of the Phoenix Chair, gave a bitter smile as he set down the report.

Submitted personally by the director of the NIS[2717], it contained a complete account of Choi Minwoo's movements the day before: the press conference held immediately after the national funeral, and the mood inside Ares Guild during its emergency meeting.

I didn't expect him to move this quickly.

Baek had already known the secret of Choi Minwoo's birth. He simply hadn't expected Minwoo to reveal it to everyone at such a perfect moment.

No. More accurately, he hadn't expected Ares Guild's executives to accept a new City Lord so easily.

That's how much Cheon Taemin's bloodline means to them.

Cheon Taemin was a hero who symbolized humanity itself. No matter how much filth the recent incidents had smeared across Ares Guild, the power of his name remained undiminished. No media outlet or celebrity dared touch a man they regarded as sacrosanct.

But that wasn't the only reason Choi Minwoo had been able to build Peace Guild into what it was today and secure the support of Ares Guild's executives.

Jin Taekyung.

Fearless, approachable, devoted. A young hero drawing closer, step by step, to Cheon Taemin's once-unrivaled reputation.

As long as he stood beside Choi Minwoo, nothing could stop the two of them. Not even if the country's most powerful politicians, chaebol[2718] corporations, and major Guilds joined forces.

"Mr. President."

Baek looked up at his chief secretary's voice.

"What is it?"

"The Guild Association is asking to see you."

Just what he least wanted to hear.

Representing the country's ten largest Guilds, the association had been watching Ares Guild for an opening ever since the Go Jun incident. They had cooperated so readily with the government not out of any desire for justice or a cleaner society, but to pick through the fallen castle's ruins for treasure.

[2717] NIS is South Korea's National Intelligence Service.

[2718] A *chaebol* is a large, family-controlled South Korean business conglomerate.

And they would have, if not for Choi Minwoo.

Minwoo was young, capable, and had legitimacy on his side. If he became Vice Guild Master, Ares Guild would rebuild. His and Jin Taekyung's good reputations could wash the filth from its name.

Opposition from the Guild Association was only to be expected. The problem was that they wanted *Baek* to reward their contributions and repay their favors.

Baek Hanseong muttered bitterly, "Not one of them knows how to behave."

"Excuse me?"

"Nothing. Put the matter of the Guild Association on hold for now."

"Mr. President, I'm sorry to say this, but their requests have been coming in without pause…"

"I said put it on hold."

The chief secretary flinched at his quiet voice, bowed, and left.

Once the door closed, Baek rubbed his tired eyes. One problem after another had worn him down, body and mind. He even found himself craving the cigarettes he had given up after his election.

But nicotine and tar weren't what he needed. He needed a solution—a way to untangle the problems knotted together like the Gordian knot of myth.

And the quickest, surest place to find one wasn't the Blue House.[2719]

Is this really the only way?

With a heavy heart, Baek pressed the button beneath his chair. Barely ten seconds later, the security officers waiting in the next room hurried in and bowed.

"I was thinking of getting some fresh air. Would that be all right?"

The head of the Presidential Security Service answered calmly. "Of course, Mr. President. Do you have a destination in mind?"

A destination.

Baek looked out the window.

"Peace Guild. Let's go to Peace Guild."

I'd been wondering why the Guild was so quiet today. The moment I left the training room at Team Leader Choi's summons and stepped inside, I found out.

"You're here, Hunter Jin Taekyung."

"…Why are you here again?"

Baek Hanseong gave my heartfelt question a weary smile.

"I've been asking myself the same thing. Still, it's good to see you again after so long."

[2719] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea's president.

"Sure."

I wasn't sure fifteen days counted as *so long*, but I pulled out a chair and sat down. Baek was turning a cigarette over in his fingers, so I added, "This is a no-smoking area."

"I know. I quit a year ago."

He rubbed at the dark circles beneath his eyes. "But lately… I've been wondering whether I should start again."

He must have had a rough time. He looked ten years older than when I'd last seen him.

I gave him a sympathetic look and patted his shoulder.

"I get that, but I'm telling you, this is a no-smoking area."

"…"

"So what brings you here?"

The question was a formality. The middle-aged man in front of me was the President. He wasn't the guy from the neighborhood bakery, free to drop by whenever he liked. There weren't many reasons for him to come in person, especially now.

Sure enough, Baek gave a humorless little laugh.

"I think you both already know."

Team Leader Choi spoke calmly. "The Guild Association's opposition must be fierce."

"It isn't only the Guild Association. But the politicians and business leaders have chosen to stand back for now."

"They'll move once they see which way the scales tip."

"Exactly. The Guild industry has the most at stake here." Baek sighed. "As you know, they're afraid of another Ares Guild."

Ares Guild was an undisputed predator. In Korea especially, it had wielded overwhelming influence since its founding. Saying it held more power than the Blue House[2720] would hardly have been an exaggeration.

"The Guild Association won't back down easily," Baek continued. "An opportunity like this may never come again. They want to weaken Ares Guild through this incident and take some of its interests as their reward."

"…"

"But then Team Leader Choi held a press conference and met with Ares Guild's leadership…"

"That must put you in a difficult position."

"Frankly, yes. They've been hounding me."

I'd been listening in silence, but I cut in. "You can be more honest than that."

[2720] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea's president.

"What do you mean?"

"You're worried too, aren't you, Mr. President? About a second Ares Guild. No—about a second Lee Jungryong."

"…!"

"Our Peace Guild is growing at a terrifying pace even as we speak. And now Ares Guild is going to bow before Team Leader Choi as well? If that happens, the game is completely over."

A corporation's strength came from its size and capital. A Guild's came from its Hunters. By that measure, Peace Guild already had standing and fighting strength far beyond the country's ten largest Guilds.

It had me and my overwhelming power. It had Team Leader Choi, Cheon Taemin's only blood descendant.

And if we add Ares Guild to that?

Team Leader Choi would wield enormous power. He'd go from the only challenger capable of bringing Ares Guild down to a power no one could touch.

"Hmm."

Baek let out a low hum. I snapped my fingers.

Tap. Fwoosh.

A flame of Samadhi True Fire flickered into being. Baek stared at it in surprise. When I nodded, he understood and put the cigarette between his lips.

Sizzle. Hoo.

White smoke poured out with his breath. Perhaps because it had been so long since he had smoked, he leaned back against the sofa and closed his eyes before suddenly removing the cigarette from his lips.

"Hunter Jin Taekyung is right. I'm more worried about a second Lee Jungryong than a second Ares Guild."

Team Leader Choi brushed the smoke aside with one hand.

"That's disappointing. I didn't know you thought of me that way, Mr. President."

"Anyone can change. Politics taught me that."

"But you came here yourself today. You even postponed your meeting with the Guild Association."

"…"

"Why?"

After a moment's silence, Baek answered with difficulty.

"Because I wanted to believe the two of you were different."

His subdued gaze rested on Team Leader Choi and me.

"What matters most isn't how strong or sharp a weapon is. It's who holds it."

He had a point. A cheap box cutter from a stationery store was a weapon in a criminal's hand. A magnificent sword made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron was a kitchen knife in a master chef's.

And the Team Leader Choi I knew was capable and wise. He wasn't the sort of man to swing a weapon carelessly just because it was in his hand.

"Then I can put your worries to rest," Team Leader Choi said quietly.

Baek's eyes lit up. "You mean…?"

"Trust me. I'll use my influence and power fairly and justly, and I'll hand over a share of the interests—enough to satisfy the Guild Association. If you like, I'll put it in writing."

"!"

"But now that I've given you the answer you wanted, I'd like a promise from you in return."

Baek blinked at the unexpected offer, then leaned forward. "What is it?"

"I don't want any more noise surrounding my actions from now on. Resolve the problem with the Guild Association, and stop the ongoing field investigation at Ares Guild headquarters."

It was an alliance founded on trust, but it was a deal too. Baek was a seasoned politician. He nodded without much hesitation.

"If you keep your word, that won't be difficult."

"Then it's settled. Nice and clean."

As though they had planned it in advance, the two men rose from their seats at the same time and extended their hands.

Just as they were about to shake, Baek turned to me.

"Hunter Jin Taekyung. May I ask one last question?"

"Me? Sure."

"Your request to stop the investigation at Ares Guild headquarters… Is it connected to the visit at the special detention center the other day?"

"Ah."

I'd figured a report would reach him. Sure enough.

My eyes met Team Leader Choi's. I read his assent there and shrugged.

"Yes."

"Huh. The investigators must have missed something."

"Why? Going to send them back in?"

"I am curious what Go Se-won was hiding, but… if I were that stupid, I would never have made it this far."

With that politician's answer, Baek smiled and took Team Leader Choi's hand.

"I hope we continue to get along."

"I look forward to working with you, Mr. President."

The newly formed super-Guild and the government had forged a firm partnership.

And the last obstacle between us and Ares Guild was gone.

“C-could you say that again?”

“Cheon. Tae as in *Crown Prince*, and Min. Cheon Taemin. That’s my maternal grandfather’s name.”

On the day of the joint national funeral for the victims, the reporters were wrapping up their coverage when a bombshell dropped on them.

They could hardly process it. Neither could anyone else, apart from the handful of people who had known in advance.

Cheon Taemin. The immortal hero shrouded in mystery for more than twenty years.

His only blood descendant, who had remained out of sight even as turmoil engulfed Ares Guild, had appeared before the cameras.

Naturally, media outlets in Korea and around the world erupted at once.

[Peace Guild Team Leader Choi Minwoo: “My Maternal Grandfather Is Cheon Taemin.”]

[Press Conference Stunned. Ten Seconds of Silence.]

[Foreign Media in Uproar: Who Is Choi, Descendant of a Living Legend?]

[Truth or Lie? Debate Erupts over Choi Minwoo’s Shocking Statement.]

[Peace Guild Spokesperson: “Choi Minwoo Confirmed as Peace Guild’s New Guild Master.”]

[Ares Guild Official: “Board Meeting Called Regarding Choi Minwoo. Appointment as New Vice Guild Master Likely.”]

[Peace Guild’s New Captain—and Ares Guild Comes Calling?]

[KakaoPage Web-Novel Reader Ttol*seu Comments on Chapter 599 of a Certain Novel: “Choi Minwoo’s a diehard Baek fan. I’ll go read the fun Gigant Rider instead.” Author’s Response: “?”]

All four of Korea’s major morning papers gave Choi Minwoo extensive coverage, as did the foreign press. Nonsense had even reached web-fiction platforms. That alone showed the scale of the uproar.

For a short while, people argued over whether his claim was true. Then Go Se-won, who knew Ares Guild’s inner workings better than anyone, and Magic Johnson spoke up.

[Former Head of Security Go Se-won: “Choi Minwoo’s Statement Is True. He Lost His Parents as a Child and Was Shut Out of Ares Guild for More Than Twenty Years.”]

[American Grand Mage Magic Johnson: “He Is Definitely Cheon Taemin’s Maternal Grandson. He Is Also a Very Capable and Charming Man Who Built Peace Guild into What It Is Today. By the Way, Where Is Kanghee Lee? Is He in the Shower?”]

[Former U.S. President Joseph Biden: “I Think So, If I Remember Right. Actually, I’m Not Sure.”]

[Prince Felix of the United Kingdom, on Hearing the News: “What The Fu*k…” Royal Household Requests Interview Be Stopped.]

The finishing touch was the Blue House’s[2721] announcement confirming Choi Minwoo’s identity and declaring its support, followed by the results of Ares Guild’s official board meeting the next day.

[Ares Guild Elects Choi Minwoo, Current Peace Guild Master, as New Vice Guild Master. “Board Vote Unanimous.”]

[Choi Minwoo: Young Power Broker Now at the Helm of Two Major Guilds.]

[Guild Association Offers “Sincere Congratulations,” Contrary to Experts’ Predictions of Opposition.]

[Immortal Hero Still Nowhere to Be Seen.]

[Overseas Reaction: “Where Is Slayer?”]

…

“Mr. Jin Taekyung?”

At the voice in my ear, I looked up from my phone. The face I’d seen in countless article photos was right in front of me.

Now Ares Guild’s new captain, welcomed with applause and cheers, Team Leader Choi regarded me calmly.

“What are you looking at?”

“Articles about you. Should I still call you Team Leader Choi? Or Guild Master now? Maybe Vice Guild Master? You’ve got a foot in each Guild. It’s confusing.”

“Whatever you’re comfortable with.”

“Hmm. How about Minwoo?”

“Ah… Guild Master Choi Minwoo would be fine.”

“That feels awkward. I’ll stick with Team Leader.”

Given his position and the people watching, Guild Master would have been the proper title. But he couldn’t refuse my suggestion. It was a hundred times better than *Minwoo*.

“…All right.”

Still looking uneasy, Team Leader Choi surveyed our surroundings.

The vast, devastated space had deliberately been left unrepaired for the investigation. We were in Area A, inside Ares Guild headquarters.

Though “formerly hidden” would be more accurate now.

[2721] The Blue House was the office and residence of South Korea’s president.

I crossed the familiar hallway. I'd fought the mutated Go Jun here, and wreckage littered everywhere I looked and stepped.

Damn, it's huge.

This wasn't an orchard, but by my rough estimate, the place covered well over a thousand pyeong[2722]—more than thirty-five thousand square feet.

And Team Leader Choi and I had to comb through it.

Well, not just the two of us. Our third member wasn't human.

"Come out, you bastard."

Swoosh.

A human-shaped creature that wasn't human emerged from my Inventory.

"Are my eyes playing tricks on me? I could've sworn you said you'd take me to a club. You promised drinking games with beautiful women."

The Skeleton King looked aggrieved. I answered with complete confidence.

"We're playing treasure hunt here."

"…"

"Find it fast and I'll really take you to a club. I swear on Hyuk Mujin's balls."

"You despicable human. I'll trust you one last time. But who *is* Hyuk Mujin, and why do you keep wagering his balls?"

I casually ignored the Skeleton King's question and gestured toward Team Leader Choi.

"You take that side. I'll take this one. Bones can handle way over there."

"The area you've assigned me seems rather large."

"Team Leader, you're hurting my feelings. If you don't like it, quit. Is he our grandfather? He's your grandfather."

"That settles it. Understood."

With the work divided, we got moving.

Three hours later, we met up again, all wearing grim expressions.

"Fuuuck… I can't do this shit."

"For some reason, the mana detector isn't working. And it's the genuine luxury model I bought at a Sotheby's auction."

"Human. Treasure hunt is boring as hell."

Knowing how meticulous Lee Jungryong was, I'd expected the secret area to be hard to find. I hadn't expected *this*.

No wonder the government investigators had come away empty-handed.

There isn't even a reaction in the office. Could the information have been wrong?

But Go Se-won knew more about Ares Guild's secrets than anyone left alive. With Lee Jungryong, Song Cheonwoo, and Go Jun dead, trusting him was our only…

[2722] One *pyeong* is about 3.31 m^2 (35.6 ft^2).

"Huh?"

A thought flashed through my mind, and my eyes widened.

Team Leader Choi stopped thumping the mana detector with his fist. He and the Skeleton King both looked at me.

"What is it?"

"Oh. Did you remember a club with a great crowd?"

"No, wait. I think I know where to look."

I quickly traced my memories of Area A: the fight with Go Jun, my first victory, and then…

When I came back, he was running away.

By then Go Jun had changed into a horrible mixture of human and monster. He'd definitely been fleeing.

The question was *where* he'd been going.

That's the place. There's something there I didn't find.

Tap—whoosh!

I launched myself forward without another thought. Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King hurried after me as I shot ahead like the wind.

We'd searched the place several times already, but this time was different.

Swoosh.

A dead-end hallway. Several rooms.

I slowed and leaned close against the wall, heightening my Qi Sense. A System chime sounded, and a blue circle spread outward from me.

It swept the hallway and every room, but no notification appeared to tell me I'd found anything.

Fwoooooosh.

The System determined the range of my Qi Sense. I could perceive only what lay within it.

But was that really all?

Farther. Wider.

I steadied my breathing. The sounds around me receded, and internal energy rose from my dantian, lending strength to my Qi Sense.

And then, at the moment my Middle Dantian finally responded—

Fwoooooosh!

The blue circle, which had stopped expanding, surged outward. Beyond the space I could see, toward another space hidden from sight.

At the edge of its reach came the notification I'd been waiting for.

Ding.

Chapter 604

Ding.

SYSTEM

- You have gained enlightenment regarding **Middle Dantian**!
- **Middle Dantian** is partially activated!
- **Middle Dantian** activation: 10%
- The efficiency of all martial arts and internal energy has increased slightly, and you may occasionally exert strength beyond your limits!
- You have achieved the rare Achievement **Waaah, I'm a Baby Middle Dantian**!
- You have gained a large amount of EXP as an Achievement reward!
- Level Up!

Activated?

I hadn't expected that.

It had been more than a month since I opened my Middle Dantian, but I'd had no idea it could do this.

And then, following the System notification announcing an unexpected reward, the news I had been waiting for arrived.

Ding.

SYSTEM

- The range of **Qi Sense** is expanding!
- The target cannot be identified precisely!
- An unidentified, strange power is being sensed!

I hadn't identified the target, but this wasn't a failure. It was a success.

Something existed beyond this wall. Certain of it, I punched the wall without hesitation.

Boom!

The solid wall burst apart, revealing empty space.

Area A, hidden on the top floor of Ares Guild headquarters, was held in place by barriers, invisibility magic, and gravity magic. The government investigators must have known that too.

The problem was that they'd missed the most important thing.

No. They couldn't have helped missing it.

I reached through the broken wall and ran my hand through the air. I felt nothing. It was empty, just as it appeared to be. The mana detector in Team Leader Choi's hand remained silent.

But I was certain something lay beyond it.

Fwoosh.

Three jiazi[2723] of Scorching Yang Qi transformed into flame. I silently looked down at my hands, bluish-white flames flickering over them, then closed my eyes and reached out.

What you see isn't everything.

It was a matter of perception. I had to see and feel with my instincts, my senses, my heart—not my eyes.

I focused every bit of my attention and poured out internal energy without restraint. My partially opened Middle Dantian responded.

The flickering flames gradually settled, completely enveloping my entire hand.

Compression. True Form.

And then…

Crack.

I gripped the flow of qi in my grasp and tore it apart with all my strength.

Shraaak!

The air split apart amid the bluish-white flames. Force dispelled spells I couldn't begin to understand, revealing an opening into another space.

The Skeleton King and Team Leader Choi stared blankly at the scene unfolding before them and muttered.

"He… tore it."

"How in the world did you…?"

"When your body's no good, your head has to do the work. Let's go."

"…Isn't it usually the other way around?"

"Usually, yes."

But I'm not usual.

At my casual reply, Team Leader Choi tossed the mana detector behind him.

Hmm. Having a good body really was the best.

It was a good thing we'd cleared the top floor in case something happened. Otherwise, we might have broadcast our entry into an unidentified subspace live.

[2723] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi correspond to 180 years.

Swoosh.

I stepped through the tall, narrow opening into a completely different world.

What the hell is this?

The space was vast and high-ceilinged, filled with a kind of elegance and extravagance I wasn't used to. Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King followed me in, too busy looking around to speak.

"That's…"

Team Leader Choi walked across the soft carpet, his eyes trembling faintly. He studied a painting hanging in the wide corridor.

"Salvator Mundi."

"Did you just call me Mundi?"

"No. That's the painting's title. *Salvator Mundi*. It's a masterpiece by Leonardo da Vinci. Have you never heard of it?"

"I've heard it from my mom now and then. She's from Gyeongsang-do."[2724]

"…"

"What's that look for? Are you looking down on Gyeongsang-do? Team Leader Choi, do you have regional prejudice?"

"What? Regional prejudice?"

That hadn't come from Team Leader Choi. The Skeleton King, who'd been looking around, butted in with an offended expression.

"Regional prejudice must be eliminated. As one born in the Demon Realm, I, too, agree with the wicked human."

"Look at this undead bastard trying to bone in on the conversation. Stay out of it."

"What the hell? I'm helping you, and you're giving me shit?"

"The Demon Realm's a different dimension, you bastard. That's dimensional prejudice. You make it sound like it's right next to Mount Jiri."

"The Gate where I operated was in Bucheon. Of course, I'm from Atlanta, Georgia, in the United States."

"Are you actually insane?"

While I argued with the Skeleton King across dimensions and borders, Team Leader Choi had given up on our conversation and started opening doors along the corridor. He called out to us.

"Both of you, stop and come over here."

The Skeleton King drew himself up like a scholar.

"This body is the lord of the undead. I do not listen to the words of a human steeped in regional prejudice."

"Come along if you don't want your ass kicked."

[2724] *Mundi* sounds like an insult in the Gyeongsang dialect, prompting the misunderstanding about the painting's title.

I grabbed the idiot by the collar and hauled him over. One look through the open doorway told me why Team Leader Choi had called us.

“What is this…?”

Not a single light was on, yet the room was as bright as day. Magic Gems sat neatly arranged on display shelves.

Even the lowest-grade gems were A-grade. By my rough count, there were around five hundred of them.

How much money is all this worth?

I couldn’t even begin to guess. And the five S-grade Magic Gems shining brightest on the top shelf were treasures you’d struggle to obtain no matter how much money you had.

“So all of this…?”

My voice trailed off. Team Leader Choi gave a small nod.

“Lee Jungryong definitely stole them. From what I’ve seen so far, the other rooms are the same.”

“This is fucking insane…”

“Not only Magic Gems, but also gold bars, diamonds, bonds, and other valuable assets. There are even countless works of art believed to have disappeared after the Great Cataclysm.”

He was right. Every door we opened on either side of the corridor revealed treasures of immense value, or treasures you couldn’t put a price on at all.

The calculator in my head had broken down long ago.

I expected him to have plenty stashed away, but… he really took a hell of a lot.

After the Great Cataclysm, Gates and Magic Gems had become a second source of oil money—no, something greater. Major Guilds had gained enough wealth and influence to overshadow powerful corporations.

Everyone, myself included, had assumed Lee Jungryong was immensely wealthy. No one could have guessed he’d hidden away this much on top of what had already been uncovered.

Vault.

The word flashed through my mind.

Right. This was the private vault Lee Jungryong had built and passed on to Go Jun.

But we couldn’t forget that this place was a prison as well as a vault.

A prison meant to hide one person from the world.

Its only two guards were dead. Beside me, the new owner of this space was walking toward the final door.

Step. Step.

At the end of the long corridor, Team Leader Choi approached the firmly shut door. He couldn’t hide the tremor in his steps.

“Hoo.”

He took a quiet breath to steady himself. I stepped ahead of him and brought my hand down like a blade toward the door, where an enormous flow of mana gathered.

A streak of flame cut through the air.

Slice! Boom!

The spells fell away, and the alloy door split to either side. Darkness and bitter cold, as though they’d been crouching beyond it, swept over us.

Whoooosh.

An inexplicable chill ran through me. I had reached the realm of Unaffected by Cold and Heat, yet I shuddered. Even the Skeleton King, a being born of death and cold, trembled.

Only one of us did not.

Step.

Footsteps rang strangely loud in the darkness. Team Leader Choi walked on without a word, all trace of trembling and hesitation gone.

More than twenty years.

A child had become a boy, and a boy had become a young man. He’d lost his parents early and been separated from his maternal grandfather without knowing why. Now, at last, he had returned to his place and stood here.

To meet his only blood relative and learn the truth.

“I missed you. I always have.”

Step.

His footsteps continued forward until, at some point, they suddenly stopped.

Before him stood a large oval mechanical capsule connected to countless wires. It looked like something out of a science-fiction movie, a device made for hibernation. A coffin made for someone still alive.

Hoo.

Team Leader Choi’s breath fogged the dust-covered glass. His long fingers trembled as he wiped it clean.

“I wanted to see you.”

As the dust came away, a face emerged. It looked older and more worn than in the photographs online.

Yet the resemblance to Team Leader Choi was unmistakable. He spoke softly to the old man.

“Grandfather.”

Team Leader Choi kept everything strictly secret. For now, no one besides the Skeleton King and me could know, and I agreed wholeheartedly.

There was one minor complication.

“Keeping a secret is easy enough. But I have two conditions.”

With the resolve of an independence activist, the Skeleton King laid them out.

“First, take me to a club. Second, give me one of the S-grade Magic Gems in there.”

Team Leader Choi readily agreed to the first. The second gave him pause, so I offered him a simple alternative.

“There’s a better way.”

“What is it?”

“How many S-grade Magic Gems do we have right now?”

“There are still five left.”

“Then let’s beat that bastard up and make it six. We can keep the secret and secure an additional S-grade Magic Gem.”

“…!”

“…!”

The Skeleton King, who had demanded his terms with the spirit of an independence activist, became a pro-Japanese collaborator and cooperated, and we reached a dramatic compromise by agreeing to take him to a club.

But for the most important matter—what to do with Cheon Taemin—we had no choice but to ask someone for help.

“We can’t keep my maternal grandfather here forever. We need to move him somewhere else.”

“The problem is moving him without anyone noticing…”

Neither a pocket enchanted with spatial expansion magic nor my Inventory could do it. The Immortal Hero, Cheon Taemin, was very much alive.

After thinking it over, only one answer remained.

“We have to move him using teleportation magic.”

What mattered was who performed it.

Someone we could trust completely. Someone who wouldn’t tell a soul even after learning the truth. Someone sympathetic to the unconscious Cheon Taemin and to us, who could continue helping us…

“Only one person comes to mind.”

“I imagine we’re thinking of the same person, Mr. Jin.”

So I made a call.

“Can you come to Korea for a bit?”

—Hey, Jin. I’m busy too. There’s a mutated Gate right now—

“Team Leader Choi wants to see you. A kiss is totally possible.”

—I’ll come right now.

Chapter 605

“Jacob, how are things over there? You’re not hurt, are you?”

On the holographic TV, an East Asian anchor with heavy eye makeup put the question to a broad-shouldered Black reporter at the scene. He winked at the camera.

“Thanks for worrying about me, Jenny. I’m fine, and so is everyone else.”

“It looks unbelievably peaceful for the site of a Mutated Gate.”

“It is. No one was hurt, and the whole thing was over in no time. Besides, this is Texas. Everyone here is tough, men and women alike.”

“Haha. That’s a relief. But where’s the hero who saved everyone?”

“Jenny, I owe you and our viewers an apology. Magic Johnson, the hero we hoped to have with us today, has already left. I did my best, but I couldn’t persuade him to stay.”

“Oh, dear.”

“He said something urgent had come up and turned down the interview. He looked so desperate to leave, I thought he was off to meet a secret lover.”

“I see. Now, Jacob, about the exact cause of this Mutated Gate…”

Hmm. A secret lover.

I leaned back on the sofa, watching the holographic TV, and found myself humming.

“When Dad goes to work, Ppoppo. Magic Johnson comes to Korea, Ppoppo.”[2725]

Whoosh! Crash!

I ducked at the sound of something cutting through the air. A crystal glass skimmed the back of my neck and smashed into the holographic TV.

Shards flew everywhere, and water pooled across the floor. My eyes met Team Leader Choi’s. He spoke calmly.

“Oh. You dodged it.”

“…”

“In case you’re wondering, that was deliberate.”

“…You’re not even going to pretend it was an accident?”

“Because it wasn’t an accident. Still, it’s a real shame. If that had been just a little faster, it would’ve smashed Mr. Jin Taekyung’s skull…”

“Hey, you don’t call a person’s head a ‘skull.‘ A skull?”

“I can when you won’t stop running that damn mouth of yours. Frankly, even ‘head’ is too good a word for a blockhead like you.”

[2725] *Ppoppo* is Korean baby talk for a kiss. Taekyung is riffing on a children’s song associated with the Korean TV program *Ppoppo Ppoppo*.

"Whoa. 'Damn head'? 'Damn mouth'?"

"Don't fall asleep in front of me from now on. If you sleep with your mouth open, I'll pour cyanide down it."

"…"

What the hell was that punchline?

He must have been furious. He practically spat the words, and the venom in them left me speechless for a moment.

I considered taking out the Myriad-Poison Ring, then politely waved a hand.

"Team Leader Choi. Calm down. This was all my fault."

"Do I look like I can calm down?"

"I'm telling you, I had no choice. You saw the news. He was busy with a Mutated Gate. What else could I do? I had to get him here first."

"By offering up my lips without asking me?"

"But I couldn't offer up my own lips, could I?"

"…!"

Whoosh! Crash!

Whoa. That one was actually close.

I narrowly dodged again and shouted, "Stop! Team Leader, stop!"

Team Leader Choi picked up a third crystal glass.

"Shut your mouth and stick your head out. Right there."

"I didn't kiss him! I didn't do it in the end!"

"You almost did!"

Team Leader Choi was just about to swing his arm with a roar that could rival a lion's roar when—

Bang.

The door flew open without a knock. In the doorway stood the Skeleton King, brimming with anticipation, and Magic Johnson, looking dejected.

"The job's done. Are we going to a club now?"

"Choi, I'm a romantic too."

Team Leader Choi stared silently at the club-obsessed parrot and the pure-hearted Grand Mage. Then, with a sigh, he lowered his hand.

Before he was an outstanding War Mage, Magic Johnson was a Grand Mage capable of wielding most forms of magic.

He had come straight to Korea after our call, and we'd told him the truth as soon as he arrived.

"Mr. Johnson. There's something we need to move…"

"Whatever the reason, I want my Ppoppo[2726] first. Ready, Choi?"

"I'm not ready, I won't be ready, and I never will be."

"Then we have a problem. I don't know what you're trying to move in such secrecy, but…"

"Actually, it isn't a thing. It's a person."

"What do you mean, Jin? A person? Are you helping someone escape?"

"I don't know if 'escape' is the right word, but it's something like that."

"Who is it? Some heinous criminal? A secret lover?"

"My maternal grandfather."

"Oh, shit. Sorry, Choi. I didn't mean to—wait. Who did you say?"

Magic Johnson had remained silent for a long time even after hearing the whole story. He didn't speak again until he saw Cheon Taemin's face for himself.

"Damn it. What the hell happened?"

"As you can see, it's a shitty situation."

"There was a reason you couldn't explain everything over the phone. All right, let's take care of the urgent matter first. Choi, where are we moving him from this prison-like place?"

After that, things moved quickly.

Magic Johnson cast Teleport to the coordinates Team Leader Choi gave him, and we all—no, one of us, trapped in a deep sleep he could hardly wake from—returned to the mansion where he had once lived.

To the home he had missed.

It was a return more than twenty long years in the making.

"Space distortion, barriers, defensive magic, of course. I've set up humidity and temperature controls too. And…"

Magic Johnson rattled off spell after spell like a wanderer riding a beat, then finished in a breathless rush.

"In short, I've done everything I can for now. There's still more work to do, though."

The Skeleton King, sulking because he hadn't gotten to go to a club, muttered, "I get that it's impressive. How impressive?"

"The place will hold unless a Grand Mage on my level—or two or three S-rank Hunters—sets out to smash it."

"That's some serious performance."

I agreed with the Skeleton King. Magic Johnson really had done everything he could for now, making it impossible for even most S-rank Hunters to detect Cheon Taemin or find his location.

[2726] *Ppoppo* is Korean baby talk for a kiss. Taekyung is riffing on a children's song associated with the Korean TV program *Ppoppo Ppoppo*.

Combat and magic are different disciplines.

There was no end to martial arts training, and the same went for magic. If I hadn't opened my Middle Dantian, I wouldn't have found Cheon Taemin so easily either.

"By the way, does anyone know who created that secret space? The magic in Area A and the spells installed there weren't beneath mine."

"This body has no idea, human."

I gave the Skeleton King's shoulder a courteous pat.

"He asked if *anyone* knew. Not if a monster knew."

"You really are a fucking bastard."

Hmm. His vocabulary was improving by the day.

Smack!

As a reward for his Vocabulary Improvement Quest, I struck the back of his head, then turned to Magic Johnson.

"I've been wondering about that too. Do you have anyone in mind?"

"Hmm. When you think about it, it would have to be another Grand Mage. Especially with magic at that level."

"Then maybe…"

"You mean the other two?"

I fell silent, uncertain. Magic Johnson shook his head, his expression unusually serious.

"Probably not. Though I do have someone in mind."

"You do?"

"Hmm."

Magic Johnson let out a low hum and seemed to sink into thought before continuing.

"I'd rather not say more yet. It's too early to be sure. But I should visit the other Grand Mages, just in case. It's been a while since I've seen them."

"I'd appreciate that."

It was welcome news. Magic Johnson had the insight of a Grand Mage, and he meant to find out for himself whether his suspicions were right.

There are currently only three Grand Mages in the world.

If one of them had accepted the job knowing full well what Lee Jungryong intended…

We couldn't let that pass. Anyone who had helped imprison the hero who saved humanity from disaster as though he were a criminal would have to answer for it.

For the sake of one person, if nothing else.

"Team Leader Choi."

He didn’t respond. Inside the cold, oval metal hibernation capsule, Team Leader Choi gazed endlessly at his grandfather, who lay in a deep sleep. Then, all at once, he spoke.

“I’ve waited for so long… but you still haven’t woken up.”

A clumsy attempt at comfort would have been worse than silence. We all knew it, and none of us spoke.

The Immortal Hero, Cheon Taemin, still hadn’t regained consciousness.

For more than twenty years.

We knew neither the cause nor the reason. Unfortunately, everything Team Leader Choi had heard from Song Cheonwoo had been true.

Lee Jungryong and Song Cheonwoo, those two ambitious men, had once tried every possible way to wake him, but in the end they’d failed. In this frustrating situation, there was only one thing we could say now.

“There has to be a way.”

“Jin’s right. An effect can’t exist without a cause. Neither can an illness.”

“Cheer up. He certainly isn’t dead yet. Even if he dies, I’ll find a way to bring him back as a Death Knight…”

Magic Johnson and I turned our killing intent on the Skeleton King. He stopped and stammered, “I-I was trying to comfort him.”

“You call that comfort, you fucking asshole?”

“Monster motherfucker…”

I was berating the Skeleton King in a voice no louder than a mosquito’s buzz so Team Leader Choi wouldn’t overhear when Choi spoke with a faint smile.

“It’s all right. We’ll find a way somehow. I’m grateful he’s alive.”

A smile didn’t mean someone was happy.

I could feel what Team Leader Choi was going through. So could Magic Johnson. Even the Skeleton King, who didn’t have a finger bone’s worth of tact, could feel it.

As though by agreement, we all fell silent. Team Leader Choi’s voice, sunk deep with emotion, pierced my ears.

“But… at least for today, I’d like to rest. Thank you all for your hard work. I truly appreciate it.”

He looked at us one by one, then bowed his head sincerely.

I understood the meaning of that gesture and was the first to walk toward the entrance.

This was a reunion that had come after more than twenty years. For a grandfather and grandson who could not even exchange a single greeting right now, it was time for us to leave them alone.

One of the most important things to Koreans was rice.

"Are you eating properly?" "Let's get a meal sometime." "What are you, *jotbap*?"[2727]

Okay, that last one was a little strange. But even our insults have *bap* in them. That's Korean culture for you.

Which meant that when Koreans finished a job, they ate together. And the best meal was rice in hot soup.

"Gukbap?[2728] What's this?"

Magic Johnson eyed Mom's homemade blood sausage gukbap[2729] with suspicion and put down his spoon.

"Hey, Jin. Got any toast?"

"Come on. Just try it."

"No, thanks. I'm not hungry."

Grrrrr.

"…You really don't have any toast?"

"Even if there were some, there isn't. If you're that reluctant, just try the broth. The broth alone."

"Damn it. Is this Korean soup? Why does it look so weird?"

Grumbling, Magic Johnson picked up his spoon and clumsily scooped up some broth.

The moment he tasted it, the game was over.

"Kheeeee. Fuck yeah."

He polished off two bowls of blood sausage gukbap[2730], saying "Fuck yeah" over and over, then smiled contentedly.

"There were so many things going wrong today that I was busy all day. I feel like I can finally breathe."

"I saw the news earlier, actually. You subdued the Mutated Gate and came straight here without even doing an interview."

"A Mutated Gate? Didn't you watch to the end?"

I couldn't. Team Leader Choi smashed the TV with a crystal glass.

I shrugged. "Why?"

"Because you wouldn't say that if you had."

Magic Johnson picked up a toothpick.

"Strictly speaking, it wasn't a Mutated Gate."

"What?"

[2727] *Jotbap* is a vulgar Korean insult for a pushover; it contains *bap*, the word for cooked rice or a meal.
[2728] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup. This version contains *sundae*, a Korean blood sausage.
[2729] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup. This version contains *sundae*, a Korean blood sausage.
[2730] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup. This version contains *sundae*, a Korean blood sausage.

What the hell was he talking about now?

Chapter 606

It wasn't a Mutated Gate? What the hell was that supposed to mean?

My confusion lasted only a moment. Then Magic Johnson dropped a single word, and my eyes widened.

"Terrorism?"

"Yeah, terrorism. An Arab man was caught trying to enter a Gate with a forged Hunter license. Turns out he was a B-rank Hunter with a terrorist group in the Middle East, and he was carrying an A-grade Magic Gem. One that hadn't been purified, of course."

"Wait. That sounds…"

"It must be a pretty familiar situation to you, Jin. Am I wrong?"

I pressed my lips together instead of answering. Recent memories flashed through my mind.

Go Jun. Song Cheonwoo. And two Monster Waves.

Something that should never have happened again kept happening.

"He was trying to cause a Monster Wave."

"Probably. No, I'm sure of it."

Damn it.

"What about the casualties?" I asked urgently. "Was anyone hurt? Did the news deliberately hide the damage because…"

I couldn't bring myself to finish.

The recent incidents had been one disaster after another. The man might not have been comparable to Go Jun, but if a B-rank Hunter from a terrorist group had absorbed an unpurified A-grade Magic Gem, he could have done considerable damage on his own.

Magic Johnson answered calmly.

"Whoa. Easy, Jin. The news reports were true. Thank God, there wasn't any significant damage."

"Are you sure?"

"Why would I lie to you?"

"But how?"

"After what happened, the whole world's on high alert. Identity checks and Magic Gem inspections have gotten several times stricter. That's how they caught him. He tried to absorb the Magic Gem as a last resort. What do you think happened?"

Magic Johnson took a sip of the instant coffee in his paper cup.

"It's simple. He couldn't withstand the power contained in the Magic Gem. By the way, this coffee is pretty good."

“Forget the coffee. If he couldn’t withstand it, shouldn’t he have mutated like Go Jun?”

Mana and magical power were like oil and water. They could never mix.

Go Jun was proof. Even as a certified S-rank Hunter trained in the modern Mana Cultivation Method, he had never managed to absorb magical power completely.

The real problem was the temporary surge of power—and the mutation waiting afterward.

So how was the result simple?

The lack of significant damage made even less sense now.

Magic Johnson’s answer took me completely by surprise.

“No. He exploded.”

“What?”

“I mean he blew apart. Into pieces. Boom!”

Bang, bang!

Magic Johnson tapped his spoon against the earthenware bowl and shrugged.

“And that was the end of everything. All I did at the scene was protect people from the blast’s aftermath.”

“…”

“In a way, you could certainly call it a suicide attack. But that was all it amounted to.”

At those words, I realized something and muttered inwardly.

It wasn’t that it was like what happened with Go Jun. It was that what happened with Go Jun had only been possible because it was Go Jun.

I’d had it backward from the start.

It came down to the size of the vessel. Not in terms of a person’s character or breadth of mind, but in terms of how much power they could contain without letting it overflow.

By that measure, Go Jun had been a large vessel. He could absorb some magical power and hold on to it, if only briefly.

And even he eventually mutated.

Go Jun had absorbed two S-grade Magic Gems at once. The balance of his vessel broke, and he finally mutated.

Even if I hadn’t intervened personally, there was a very good chance he would have died after holding out for only a little longer.

An ordinary Hunter wouldn’t stand a chance.

The terrorist in today’s news had been a B-rank Hunter, but the power had still blown him apart on the spot. He hadn’t been able to control any of the magical power in that Magic Gem.

“Hey, Jin. Looks like you’re getting it.”

Magic Johnson was grinning. I let out a short, disbelieving laugh.

"That's a huge relief."

"It is. Only a complete idiot would try the same thing after today."

Magic Johnson had put his finger on what mattered. It was fortunate that the terrorist attack had caused no damage, but the greater relief was that it would deter similar incidents in the future.

"The terrorist group must have realized it, too. To put it coldly, this was a terrible trade from their perspective."

A trained Hunter was a valuable asset, and a Magic Gem was an energy source of immense value. I didn't know how the group had gotten hold of an unpurified A-grade Magic Gem, but today they'd failed spectacularly.

They had lost both a valuable operative and a Magic Gem easily worth several billion won[2731].

"They'll change tactics," Magic Johnson said. "Probably go back to targeting defenseless civilians with that damn magic wand of Allah. But it's too early to let our guard down."

He sighed quietly.

"Terrorist organizations have been making some worrying moves lately. I hear they've been experimenting with Gates and Magic Gems, especially in Africa and the Middle East. The information came from the Pentagon, so it's reliable."

The Skeleton King, who had spent the entire conversation fiddling with his smartphone without participating, perked up his ears.

"The Pentagon? Are we going there right now? Is much rub-rub possible?"

"Just so you know, it's not a club."

"Damn it. I thought I was finally going to meet some hot girls."

Don't even dream about it, you bastard…

The Pentagon was the headquarters of the United States Department of Defense. If the Skeleton King's identity came to light, its researchers would party all night.

In a heavily secured laboratory, of course, where they'd try all kinds of rub-rub with every experimental tool they had.

"Hmm. Everyone would certainly be happy if we took him to the Pentagon," Magic Johnson said.

"Not so good for you or me, though."

"True. We'd probably stand trial for violating international law. Though if a terrorist group caused trouble while the trial was going on, the whole thing might fizzle out."

Life was hard. The moment one problem was solved, another popped up.

A terrorist group.

[2731] Several billion won—roughly 2–9 billion won—is about $1.4–6.4 million and €1.3–5.8 million.

Once the series of incidents caused by Go Jun became known to the world, every country had been thrown into shock and heightened alertness.

But terrorist groups had gained another weapon.

If the information Magic Johnson had obtained from the Pentagon was true, they would find a way no matter what it took.

"…Of all times," I muttered.

Magic Johnson looked puzzled.

"Of all times? What do you mean?"

"Hmm."

I hesitated, then shook my head.

"It's nothing. Don't worry about it."

"It sounds like something, and it's bothering me a lot."

"It's just… there's something I've been preparing to do. But after hearing that, I'm hesitating for now."

"Something you've been preparing?"

I gave a small nod.

I hadn't told anyone yet. It was one of the things I'd decided to do when I returned to the modern era this time.

For myself, and for everyone else, I had made a decision after a long period of hesitation and had been preparing for it…

But this changes things.

Humanity had regained peace after the Great Cataclysm. That didn't mean the whole world was peaceful.

Mana had appeared, along with Awakened people. Those who survived and came out strong had remade the world by their own rules, and conflicts everyone thought had ended were still going on.

No. Some people would even say they've only gotten worse.

Magic Gems were more valuable and useful than oil. Gates were mines that kept spitting out those diamonds. Conflict over them was inevitable, whether the people involved called themselves entrepreneurs, Guilds, or rebels.

The terrorist groups in the Middle East were more dangerous still.

They called awakening a blessing from God and held it up as proof that God existed. You might ask what the hell they were talking about when even atheists could Awaken, but looking for logic in people like that was a mistake to begin with.

Warriors chosen by God! Advance!

God wills it!

I had no idea which god or doctrine had told them to do such idiotic things.

But singers sang, blacksmiths worked iron, and idiots kept doing idiotic things. They fought across the world, dying or ending up crippled.

And they were still at it right now.

Bastards.

The Skeleton King was a lot better than them. He might have started out as a monster, but by now he'd shown as much sacrifice and dedication as any Hunter.

Good lad.

At the warmth in my gaze, the Skeleton King glared at me ferociously.

"You just cursed this body in your thoughts."

"…What the hell? That's absurd."

"Tell me the truth. I'll let it slide."

"Johnson, can't we just take this bastard to the Pentagon?"

Magic Johnson grinned.

"Shall we?"

"You hear that? You're finished, you experimental-subject bastard."

"Now that it's come to this, going right away wouldn't be bad."

"Tell them to prepare a cauldron. We'll make some bone broth out of this bastard."

"I don't know about a cauldron, but the laboratory will be ready whenever we are."

For some reason, Magic Johnson and I were on exactly the same wavelength today.

He played along without missing a beat, then drew a staff from inside his clothes.

"Well, now that we've eaten, shall we get going?"

"Sounds good… Wait."

I'd answered on reflex. Then I felt mana circulating through his staff and gave him an uneasy look.

"Uh, there's no need to go that far."

"Don't you have a traditional Korean proverb? Once a gay draws his magic wand, he must pierce even a radish."

"…?"

That sounded like a strange and impressive twist on a proverb I'd never heard in my life. I swallowed.

"Wait. Seriously?"

"Yeah. Seriously."

"You're not joking?"

"The Pentagon sent an official request two days ago. They want your advice and your help, Jin. As soon as possible."

"What?"

I blinked, then let out a hollow laugh.

"Oh, I get it. This is an American joke."

Magic Johnson fixed me with the profound gaze of a gay man.

“How did you know? I don’t remember showing you that memory.”

What the fuck is he talking about?

I stood there blankly for a moment before hurriedly waving my hands.

“…No, I got the pronunciation mixed up. Joke. Joke. A gag.”

“I know. That was a joke, too.”

He flashed a white-toothed grin.

“But the part about the Pentagon wasn’t.”

“…!”

“Let’s go. It looks like someone else is already ready. Isn’t that right?”

I followed his gaze and turned my head. I sensed a familiar presence, and a figure came into view.

Team Leader Choi answered in a subdued voice.

“Of course, Mr. Johnson.”

Chapter 607

The Pentagon.

The massive pentagon-shaped building was practically impregnable.

A security force of some thousand guards, every one of them a high-ranking Hunter. Immense flows of mana surrounded the building inside and out. That alone told you what kind of place the Pentagon was.

“Impressive, isn’t it?”

Magic Johnson had just finished the authentication process. Seeing Team Leader Choi and me looking around wide-eyed, he gave us a knowing grin.

“Since it was first built during World War II, the Pentagon has only been attacked twice. Once on 9/11, and once during the Great Cataclysm. You both know how those turned out.”

Team Leader Choi nodded.

“Even the Demon King Asmodeus and his monster army’s all-out assault couldn’t bring it down.”

“That’s right. It was the second fiercest battle of my life. The first was the Day of Victory, of course. Both times, one person helped me escape with my life.”

Any person on Earth, not just an American, knew that fact.

During the Great Cataclysm and afterward, only one person had been able to stop the demon who descended upon this world: the Demon King Asmodeus.

“Cheon Taemin. If your maternal grandfather—the man Americans call Sky—hadn’t been there, neither I nor this Pentagon would exist today.”

Magic Johnson was gazing at Team Leader Choi with distant eyes, as though remembering something, when a voice came out of nowhere.

“I was thinking the same thing, Johnson.”

It wasn’t Team Leader Choi or me. Naturally, it wasn’t the Skeleton King hiding in my Inventory, either.

Clomp. Clomp.

Heavy footsteps. Wrinkled jeans and a shirt. White hair tangled into a complete mess.

An elderly white man with one side of his face badly distorted strode up to us and thrust out both hands.

“I don’t know which of you two I should shake hands with first, so I’ll do both at once. I’m Chuck Hagel. You can just call me Chuck.”

He didn’t just give off the air of a tough Texan. It practically poured out of him.

His face looked familiar. I stared at it as I took his hand.

“I’m Jin Taekyung. But are you, by any chance…?”

“That Chuck Hagel? Yep. I’m not as famous as you, but I cut down my fair share of monsters back in the day.”

“Oh. Ooooh.”

I’d suspected it when I saw him, but the old man really was the previous generation’s S-rank Hunter known as Uncle Chuck.

I had never imagined I would meet one of the war heroes from the Great Cataclysm whom I had admired as a child. With a cry of delight, I vigorously shook his hand up and down.

“I’m a fan. A real fan. I even collected your Hunter cards in elementary school.”

“Hunter cards? They sold those in South Korea?”

“They probably sold them in North Korea, too. I bought them every time I got my allowance.”

“Huh. So here’s another dumb little kid who handed me a fortune in royalties. Of course, I spent the lot on alimony from five divorces.”

Chuck Hagel smiled contentedly, having demolished a childhood memory in a single sentence.

“If you still have any of my cards, bring them by sometime. I’ll sign them if you want.”

“Ah, I traded them all away.”

“What?”

“I collected ten and traded them for a Cheon Taemin card my friend had. Honestly, Uncle Chuck cards weren’t that rare.”

“…”

The smile vanished from Chuck Hagel’s face. He sighed.

“Damn it. And of all people, it had to be Mr. Sky. Can’t argue with that.”

“There’s no comparing their rarity or value. My friend wanted twenty cards at first, but I kept haggling until…”

“…I get it. I get it. You can stop now.”

Chuck Hagel shook his head repeatedly, then shook hands with Team Leader Choi.

“You’re the spitting image of your maternal grandfather. Good to meet you, Choi.”

“It’s a pleasure, Mr. Hagel.”

“I told you to call me Chuck. If you were one of those other idiots with nothing but shit in their heads, that would be different. But you and the traitor beside you have earned the right.”

Look at him calling me a traitor just because I traded some cards.

As I grumbled to myself, Team Leader Choi replied calmly.

“Please understand, Mr. Hagel. I wouldn’t feel comfortable calling the man in charge of the Pentagon—and the United States Secretary of Defense—by his first name.”

"Hm. Is that so? Come to think of it, I suppose you do have to worry about what people think. You're in charge of two massive Guilds now, after all."

I blinked.

"The man in charge of the Pentagon? The Secretary of Defense?"

"Hm? You didn't know?"

"Obviously not."

"Really? Everyone else seemed to know. I assumed Johnson had at least told you."

Under the Secretary of Defense's gaze, the Grand Mage—widely expected to become the next Secretary of Gukbap[2732]—scratched his chin.

"I figured you knew, too. Jin, you really didn't?"

At this point, I felt like I had somehow become an idiot. I replied with some reluctance.

"I really didn't. Were you appointed a few days ago? Ah, that must be why I hadn't heard."

Chuck Hagel's answer was short and blunt.

"This is my eighth year."

"…Oh."

"Well, you had no particular reason to know. It's hardly important compared to what we're about to discuss. Come on, everyone. Follow me."

Chuck Hagel pulled a cigar from the breast pocket of his dress uniform and put it in his mouth as naturally as could be. He led the way, and we followed.

Each time he puffed on the cigar, acrid smoke rose to the ceiling. An alarm sounded, and a red light began to flash.

Wee-oo! Wee-oo!

> Fire hazard! Fire hazard!

Bang!

Chuck Hagel smashed the warning light without a moment's hesitation.

"Fucking siren."

Forget tough guy. Forget petty bastard. This man was insane.

The Skeleton King, who had made it through the security checkpoint hidden in my Inventory, whispered,

"Is he human? Are you sure he isn't a monster?"

I had my doubts, too. But he matched the description on the Hunter cards I'd collected as a kid.

[2732] *Gukbap* is rice served in hot soup. Jin replaces *bang* ("defense") in *gukbang-bu-jang-gwan*, "Secretary of National Defense," with *bap*, creating the nonsensical title "Secretary of Gukbap."

Born in Texas. Dreamed of becoming a cowboy. Supposedly tamed a Minotaur with his fists and rode it around. And that was just the beginning.

Clomp. Clomp.

No one was brave enough to stand in Chuck Hagel's way as he marched forward without hesitation.

Researchers, Hunters, and employees who appeared to belong to the Pentagon split to either side as if facing a disaster. Moses, who had a cigar in his mouth instead of a staff, crossed between them while spewing smoke like a chimney.

He didn't forget to talk trash along the way.

"When the hell are they going to widen this damn hallway? Every time I see it, I want to smash it to pieces."

"Hey, Smith. Put that electronic cigarette away while I'm asking nicely. If you waft that shitty strawberry scent in front of me one more time, I'll put you on the list of people who died in the line of duty. Cigars are fine, though."

"Gordon. There's a smashed warning light in Section Three. Go fix it. Who broke it? Listen carefully: your fucking direct superior."

No one could stop Chuck Hagel as he rampaged through the Pentagon like an enraged bull.

In the roughly five minutes it took us to reach our destination, poor Smith was forced to change his e-cigarette liquid, innocent Gordon ran off at full speed to repair the warning light, and seven more lights warning of a fire hazard met the same fate beneath the clouds of cigar smoke.

Gordon would probably have to fix those, too.

"…"

This guy really was out of his mind.

I was wondering who'd had the insane idea of making him Secretary of Defense when Magic Johnson leaned over and whispered,

"Hey, guys. Chuck's been touchy lately because of the terrorist problem. He's a good guy at heart. Cut him some slack."

The moment he finished speaking, Chuck Hagel slammed his fist into the wall.

"This goddamn hallway! Hallway! Hallway! Didn't I tell you to make the hallway wider?"

Bang! Bang! Kraaang!

Team Leader Choi watched the hallway widen, then asked with complete sincerity,

"Is he really a good person?"

"…Probably. Whatever he looks like right now, he's outstanding as Secretary of Defense. Capable, and he gets things done."

Of course he got things done. Get even slightly on Chuck Hagel's nerves, and your life would be over.

As Magic Johnson's answer trailed off with noticeably less confidence, Chuck Hagel passed through a mana-recognition device and pointed to a tightly shut door.

"We're here already. Everyone, this is Building Five."

"Building Five?"

"Also called the E-Ring. And for what it's worth, as far as I know, no foreigner has set foot in here for twenty-five years."

Chuck Hagel looked at Team Leader Choi and grinned.

"Only one outsider on Earth was ever free to come and go as he pleased. Mr. Sky. He was treated the same as the President of the United States."

Even without the rest, the fact that *Chuck Hagel* unfailingly called him "Mr. Sky" said plenty about Cheon Taemin's standing.

"And now his maternal grandson and a young hero have taken up the baton. Both of you… welcome to Building Five."

The instant Chuck Hagel finished speaking, brilliant light poured from the entire door.

Whoosh!

No. It wasn't light. It was magic.

I let the flow of mana sweep over my whole body without resisting it. Dazzling brightness filled my vision, and the space around us warped.

This is…

The moment I realized that this familiar sensation was Teleport, I blinked and found myself in a completely unfamiliar new space.

As my vision rapidly returned, I saw people seated around a pentagonal table.

"Then the forces being deployed to the Middle East front will be… Oh. It seems our guests have finally arrived."

Beep.

With a mechanical chime, the hologram illuminating the dark conference room disappeared. A neat-looking middle-aged man at the head of the table stopped speaking and rose.

I knew his face at once.

He was a man whose position kept him constantly exposed in every form of media. He looked older than he had on television and radiated even more charisma than he had in the newspapers.

"You're later than I expected, Secretary Hagel. I hope you haven't smashed another innocent warning device."

At the man's amused remark, Chuck Hagel snapped the glowing tip off his cigar with his fingers.

"Take it out of my salary."

“The Treasury Secretary asked me to pass on a message. Your entire salary for this month has already gone toward repairing the damage you’ve done to the Pentagon.”

“Damn it. Again? At this rate, I’ll be too afraid of alimony to get divorced.”

Chuck Hagel let out a sighing mutter, then turned toward us.

“No need for introductions, I assume?”

At least this time, there was no need.

Team Leader Choi knew who the man was. So did I. Even the Skeleton King knew.

“Wicked human. Is that old human perhaps…?”

That was right. I gave a small nod as the middle-aged man approached with measured steps, and murmured his name to myself.

Donald Doramp Jr.

His title was better known than his name: President of the United States.

Chapter 608

I stared at the middle-aged man before me.

Donald Doramp Jr.

A tycoon with a business empire and a fortune worth trillions of won[2733], he had followed his father, a former U.S. president, into office. They were the third father-and-son pair to hold the presidency in United States history.

Neat as a British gentleman, he looked twenty years younger than he was. His smile as he greeted us was genuine.

“Welcome, both of you.”

Unlike his father, President Doramp wore his hair neatly combed back. We shook his hand.

I’d seen the President of the United States on television and in online articles, but I’d never imagined meeting him. Even with him standing right in front of me, I could hardly believe it.

“Haha, there’s no need to look at me like that. If anything, I’m the one who’s amazed. After hearing so much about you both, I finally get to meet you.”

Team Leader Choi answered in fluent English.

“Thank you for welcoming us, Mr. President.”

“I know a joint national funeral was held in Korea. My condolences to the victims who lost their lives so tragically, and to Mr. Kim, the former Guild Master of the Peace Guild. May they rest in peace.”

President Doramp was a gentleman in manner as well as appearance.

He had already done the proper thing by sending the U.S. ambassador to Korea and the Secretary of State to the funeral. Yet he had remembered to offer his condolences in person, too.

“Come to think of it, you’ve already met the Secretary of State, haven’t you? Isn’t that right, Jesse?”

At his call, the middle-aged woman seated at the pentagonal table smiled and greeted us with a glance.

Only then did it hit me: the people in this room were the ones holding up the superpower that was the United States.

The top brass of the U.S. military and government.

Only a few wore suits. The Secretary of State, whom I’d met briefly at the funeral, was among them. The others were probably cabinet members or held positions just as high.

As for the military…

There are a shitload of them.

[2733] For a fortune of roughly ₩2–9 trillion, about $1.4–6.4 billion and €1.3–5.8 billion.

It was a feast of stars, literally.

Middle-aged and elderly generals, their hair either going gray or already white, watched us with curiosity. Insignia and stars gleamed on their dress uniforms.

“Ah, I’m late with the introductions.”

President Doramp noticed where I was looking and continued.

“Everyone, this is Mr. Choi, who leads the Peace Guild and Ares Guild. And this is Mr. Jin, whom you all know. As for the people here…”

Jack. Philip. Joey. Liam. Isabella.

Names and titles I’d heard in Hollywood war movies flew past me.

Team Leader Choi seemed to know every face and name, as usual. I just stared and nodded.

How many departments and titles are there?

The only people who stuck in my mind were the directors of the CIA and FBI. Probably because those organizations showed up in movies so often.

“Now that we’ve made the introductions, I should tell you why we brought you here so suddenly.”

Snap. Fwoosh!

The instant President Doramp snapped his fingers, the holograms that had briefly disappeared filled the room in every direction.

This is…

A map. Not of the whole Earth, but a detailed map of one region.

Coordinates hovered over countless buildings and stretches of terrain. Markers whose meaning I couldn’t guess glittered here and there like stars.

Oh.

The place names. The deserts scattered across the map. And what President Doramp had been saying when we arrived.

I put it together and muttered, “The Middle East?”

“It’s a tactical map showing the locations of the terrorist groups. The sparkling markers are probably Gates or their bases.”

Team Leader Choi had spoken almost at the same time as me. President Doramp nodded to us both.

“You’re both right, though Mr. Choi’s answer is more detailed and closer to the mark. The lights indicate suspected terrorist bases. Hologram, zoom out.”

Whoosh.

The enlarged map shrank into a globe. It turned slowly at President Doramp’s gesture, lights large and small scattered across its surface.

“All of those are terrorist groups?”

"When my late father was president, there were already more than a hundred Islamic terrorist organizations alone. After the Great Cataclysm, of course, they multiplied at a frightening rate."

That was news to me.

More than a hundred Islamic terrorist organizations *before* the Great Cataclysm. Who knew how many there were now?

Sure, some were probably little groups that operated on the scale of clubs. The problem was, they weren't meeting to talk about comics. They carried out attacks to kill people.

Seriously, why are there so many?

I knew the world had plenty of lunatics. I'd never imagined there were this many.

Team Leader Choi watched the hologram, his gaze dark.

"Does that exclude the rebel forces scattered across Africa?"

"A good question, Mr. Choi. Fortunately, the rebels are included."

"Just as you said, Mr. President, that truly is fortunate. And I think I understand why you went out of your way to invite us."

His voice dropped.

"You're planning to launch an operation to wipe out the terrorist groups, aren't you?"

"That's right."

President Doramp gave a grave nod.

"As both of you know, the United States is still the world's greatest power, but that also means we face an equal amount of opposition. Therefore, we have no choice but to act cautiously, both militarily and diplomatically."

The United States might have a long history as the world's bully, but even it couldn't push around every country on Earth. That was especially true after it had suffered the worst losses in the Great Cataclysm.

"But the terrorist groups and rebels operating around the world must be eliminated as soon as possible. I'm sure you both know why."

Of course I did.

As Magic Johnson had told us, the terrorist groups and African rebels had begun experimenting with Gates and Magic Gems.

I didn't know what those experiments would produce, or whether they would succeed. But the experiments alone were dangerous enough.

Like nuclear tests.

The whole world paid attention whenever North Korea tested a missile.

Koreans, of course, just thought, *Those bastards are at it again,* and got on with their day. But that was because we knew they weren't going to fire at us.

Terrorist groups were as crazy as North Korea. Crazier, even.

“You must have heard from Mr. Johnson. Today alone, terrorist groups carried out the same kind of attack simultaneously in California, Arizona, and Texas. And this isn’t happening only in the United States.”

President Doramp swept a hand through the hologram.

The globe vanished. Dozens of small windows took its place.

> “Surrender! Put down your weapons now, and…!”
>
> “God is great!”
>
> “R-run!”
>
> “BOOM!”

Dozens of languages, translated for me by the System, mingled in a deafening clamor.

People of different appearances and skin colors fled explosions or screamed as human bone and flesh sprayed over them.

“There have been thirty-two attempted attacks around the world today alone. Fortunately, as with the incident in Texas that made the news, the damage so far has been minor. But if the terrorist groups complete their experiments with the Gates and Magic Gems in their possession…”

Chuck Hagel, fiddling with his cigar, cut in.

“Fuck. Everything goes to shit. Monster Waves will break out at any time, anywhere, just like what happened in South Korea.”

Magic Johnson spoke with a sigh.

“And the rebels won’t stay quiet, either. They’re just as dangerous as the terrorist groups. They kidnap even children, brainwash them, and use them as soldiers. If it meant taking over a country, they wouldn’t bat an eye even if tens or hundreds of thousands of people died.”

Why did that remind me of the saying that human beings were capable of both the greatest good and the greatest evil?

The bodies of the people who had died before my eyes only weeks ago came back to me. So did their screams. A weight settled in my chest.

“Hmm.”

I glanced sideways at Team Leader Choi with a low hum.

His gaze was deeply sunken as he remembered someone who had left his side not long ago.

That can’t happen again.

I didn’t know how cruel people could become, or how many had to die or be hurt before this insane wheel stopped turning.

But at the same time, I felt relieved. I possessed enough power to stop that endlessly turning wheel, even if only for a moment.

And if I couldn't stop it…

I'll break it.

Having already made up my mind, I looked at President Doramp and suddenly spoke.

"When will the operation to wipe them out begin?"

He understood what I meant. A smile spread across his face, and at his signal, someone at the pentagonal table stood.

"Assuming the entire UN Security Council agrees, we estimate that it will take two months at the earliest to complete all preparations. At the longest, it may take more than six months."

"Two months at the earliest?"

Slow. Far slower than I'd expected.

I frowned.

"Considering how dangerous you've said the situation is, doesn't that seem like an awfully long time?"

"International law leaves us little choice. Deploying troops to countries in the Middle East and Africa without their consent would be a clear violation of their sovereignty."

"Funny. My modern history textbooks made it look like you fought in the Middle East just fine. I watched a documentary criticizing the oil money involved, too."

The key government official who had been listening suddenly lost his ability to speak and cleared his throat.

"Ahem… That was because of the 9/11 attacks. Under the new international agreements made after the Great Cataclysm—"

"Never mind. Two months really is the absolute earliest?"

"Ahem. Yes."

I thought for a moment, then leaned close to President Doramp and whispered.

"Can I ask you something?"

"Anything."

"Suppose someone nobody could identify—some mysterious stranger, for example—wiped out the African rebels or the terrorist groups in the Middle East. Would *that* break international law?"

"Pardon?"

"Batman. Spider-Man. Someone like that. And lower your voice before you answer."

President Doramp stared blankly at me. When he finally caught on, he struggled to get the words out.

“So you’re saying that Mr. Jin would hide his identity and launch an operation against the terrorist groups…?”

“Me? Why would I?”

“But what you just said—”

“I never said that. It was an example.”

“W-wait, Mr. Jin.”

“This man is going to cause a disaster. Why would I do something like that alone? Unless I were some lunatic who stormed into Ares Guild headquarters by himself.”

“…”

A suffocating silence filled the room.

President Doramp stared at me as if I were insane. At last, he spoke.

“It seems I misunderstood. What an absurd thought.”

“Right?”

“Yes. In that case, we’ll end today’s meeting here. I’m going to leave the holographic tactical map behind by accident.”

“Ah. An accident.”

“Yes. It’s top-secret—more secret than any other classified information—so it must never be leaked outside. Especially since it contains the precise locations of rebel forces in the Middle East and Africa.”

“Anything else?”

“Everything necessary is in the materials. Not that you’ll have any opportunity to obtain them, Mr. Jin. You’ll be heading straight back to Korea, won’t you, Mr. Johnson?”

Magic Johnson had caught on. He nodded.

“Of course, Mr. President. Though Jin likes to travel. I wonder if it would be all right for me to take a few days off and spend some time with him.”

“Is that so? Is there anywhere you particularly like to—”

“Africa and the Middle East,” I said without drawing breath. “I go crazy for deserts. My dream is to pee in an oasis and give the Sphinx some Churu[2734].”

Team Leader Choi added calmly, “I was born in summer, so I like hot places.”

“Well. What a coincidence.”

“Ready, Choi?”

“Of course, Johnson… No, that sounds a little strange.”

The conversation was bewildering, yet somehow going remarkably smoothly. Chuck Hagel clamped his cigar between his teeth and put an end to it.

“A lunatic is going to kill lunatics.”

He was right. Lunatics ought to die at the hands of a lunatic.

[2734] Churu is a lickable cat treat.

It was an ordinary day.

Muhammad Saladir ad-Din, leader of an armed Islamic terrorist group, had interrogated a foreign prisoner and killed a subordinate who'd gotten mouthy. Then he returned to his bedroom.

Before he could take off his outer clothes, he found an uninvited guest waiting for him.

"Stand up straight, Hassan."

"…?"

Chapter 609

"Stand up straight, Hassan."

"…?"

Muhammad Saladir ad-Din, leader of a massive Islamic terrorist group, was momentarily taken aback.

Who the hell was Hassan? And whose voice had just spoken in his bedroom, where no one else should have been?

But if something this minor could make him lose his composure, he never would have risen to his current position.

Muhammad answered calmly.

"Sorry, but I'm not Hassan. I don't know who you are, but you seem to have mistaken me for someone else."

"I don't think so."

Step.

The uninvited guest emerged from the darkness, speaking flawless Arabic without a syllable out of place. When Muhammad saw the intruder's face, he narrowed his eyes.

What the hell? Who is this strange bastard?

The man's features were impossible to make out, but the mask covering his face was bizarre enough on its own.

It wasn't a turban or a strip of cloth. It was made of thick red yarn, with gaping holes for his eyes and mouth.

Calling it a mask was strange enough. Muhammad had never seen a lunatic wear anything like it in the scorching desert.

"Who are you?" he asked.

The man, who appeared to be an assassin, answered.

"I'm Mami…"

"Mami?"

"No, I'm a back scratcher."

"…?"

A filial son was one thing, and a hand was another. What the hell was a "filial son's hand"[2735] supposed to be?

One thing was certain: the man hadn't come to practice filial piety.

"Who sent you?"

"Allah."

"Allah?"

[2735] *Hyojason*, the Korean word for a back scratcher, literally means "a filial son's hand."

"Yeah. That Allah you're always sucking off."

Muhammad saw the corner of the man's mouth lift through the hole in his mask.

"He told me to tell you he never ordered any of that shit, so stop interpreting the scripture however the fuck you want."

"You insane bastard."

"I never thought I'd live to hear a terrorist leader call me an insane bastard. What a shitty life."

Muhammad considered when to draw the scimitar at his waist, then spoke with an air of authority.

"You fool. Do you really think you'll get away with this?"

"Yep. I think I'll be fine."

"You seem eager to die. If you surrender now…"

"Yeah, I think I heard that a minute ago. Hang on."

The man rummaged through his clothes, then pulled something from his sleeve and tossed it.

Thud. Roll…

A round object landed with a heavy thud and rolled to Muhammad's feet.

Healthy bronze skin, like a desert warrior's. Eyes frozen wide open. Not a drop of blood stained the cleanly severed neck.

"K-Kasim?"

"Why are you so surprised? Know him?"

"…!"

Muhammad froze solid.

Kasim was the bodyguard and assassin he trusted more than anyone.

An S-rank Hunter unknown to the world, Kasim was an Awakened assassin whose victims were too numerous to count.

He killed Kasim? So quickly and quietly that no one noticed?

Allah help me. This is real.

Fear gripped Muhammad's entire body, and his voice trembled.

"I-I'll give you one last chance. Leave now, and I'll forget what happened today. There'll be no retaliation."

"N-No, dumbass. Why bother with all that when I can just kill you?"

"T-Then I'll give you as much wealth as you want! Diamonds! What about diamonds?"

His ultimate diamond attack!

"Diamonds? The ones in the safe under your desk? I already took those. They were pretty."

But it had no effect! Muhammad's world went dark!

“Bodyguards! Bodyguarrrds! Omari! Sadat! Nasser! Where are you all?”

Muhammad had lost his composure. As he screamed their names, the intruder called along with him.

“Omari! Sadat! Nasser! Right here!”

Thud. Thud. Thud.

“Woohoo! Bodyguard heads acquired!”

How had all those heads come out of that narrow sleeve?

Muhammad stared in horror at the three heads that had fallen one after another. Then—

Bang!

The door, which had remained firmly shut despite the commotion in the bedroom, flew open. A huge man wearing the same kind of mask walked in.

“Is this terrorist asshole still alive?”

Blood soaked his hands. Muhammad froze like a statue, and the intruder raised a hand in greeting.

“There’s still work to do. Are you finished cleaning up?”

“More or less. The other two are downstairs looking around. By the way, can’t I take off this shitty mask? I’ve been suffocating in it.”

“No.”

“Damn it. Then at least let me smoke a cigar. My face is covered by illusion Magic anyway.”

“Why not hang your ID around your neck? Anyone with half a brain would account for illusion Magic. You’re already huge, and with your skills, smoking a cigar would practically advertise that you’re Chuck Hagel.”

Muhammad’s eyes widened as he realized something.

“C-Chuck Hagel? You bastards! You’re from the United States!”

“Gasp. How did this bastard figure that out? Chuck, there must be a spy among the U.S. leadership.”

As the intruder recoiled in surprise, Chuck Hagel put a cigar between his teeth and muttered,

“…Crazy Korean.”

“No, Chuck. Are you insane? If you say Korean here, he’ll understand us.”

“I think I’m going to lose my mind. I think I’m going to lose my mind. I think I’m going out to eat lunch…”

But Chuck Hagel wasn’t the one on the verge of losing his mind. Muhammad was.

As if the name Chuck Hagel hadn’t been enough, now he’d heard *Korean*.

He couldn’t help thinking of the most famous Korean in the world right now.

“J-Jin Taekyung?”

“No, I’m a back scratcher.”

“D-Don’t give me that bullshit. Who do you think you’re fooling—”

Whoosh! Slash!

Muhammad’s jeweled turban flew off. Even the few strands of hair left on his head were cut away as if erased.

The strange man—or rather, Jin Taekyung—asked the frozen Muhammad, who had forgotten how to breathe.

“I’ll ask again. Who am I?”

“A-A back scratcher.”

“You said Jin Taekyung a moment ago.”

“I-I was mistaken. I must have mistaken you!”

“Really? Can you swear to God?”

“I-I swear by mighty Allah and the Prophet Muhammad! You’re a back scratcher!”

“How dare you swear by God and lie? I’m Jin Taekyung, you apostate bastard!”

“Gyaaaaaah!”

Muhammad, seized by terror, screamed with all his strength. But the sound vanished without ever leaving the bedroom.

A barrier of qi, formed from powerful internal energy, sealed the space without the slightest gap.

“W-Why the hell are you doing this to me?”

Muhammad was crying now. Chuck Hagel let out a quiet laugh.

“Don’t ask us. Ask the god whose name you’ve been peddling. You’ll meet him soon enough anyway.”

“…!”

“Oh. Of course, there’s something you need to do first.”

Muhammad didn’t hear Chuck Hagel’s last words. What he’d said before filled Muhammad’s mind to bursting.

Meet God? I’m going to die? Me?

Death.

Every human being thought about that word, but not Muhammad. He had always been the one who dealt death, never the one on the receiving end.

A shrill voice slipped between his trembling lips.

“T-That can’t be. It can’t.”

He had joined an armed terrorist organization as a boy. Instead of a pen, he’d held an automatic rifle; after awakening, he’d taken up a sword.

He had risen through the ranks to lead a terrorist organization, kidnapping, imprisoning, and brutally executing countless people.

Muhammad shared a name with the prophet of old. He believed himself a new prophet and leader.

But then… why?

“I-I’m under God’s protection. How could this…”

“It’s simple.”

The corners of Jin Taekyung’s mouth, which had been raised through the holes in his mask, slowly sank.

When Jin Taekyung spoke, his voice had turned cold.

“You’re a fucking lunatic who’s used God’s name to do every kind of insane shit. That’s why you’re dying.”

“…!”

“Attacking civilians. Kidnapping kids and brainwashing them. Strapping bombs to their bodies for suicide attacks… I can’t even list everything. There’s too much.”

Hack. Ptooey.

Chuck Hagel spat, and the phlegm landed thickly on Muhammad’s face. His rough voice followed, cutting into Muhammad’s ears.

“So I’ll give you one last chance. You’re a fucking terrorist bastard who’d have no right to complain if Johnson tormented you all week. But cooperate, and maybe you’ll have something to say for yourself before God.”

“W-What does that mean?”

“It doesn’t mean we’re letting you live. But you might die with a little less pain.”

“W-What the hell do you want?”

“Orders.”

“What?”

“We know you have countless branches under your command. We also know about the other armed terrorist organization at odds with you. The problem is that wiping them out one by one would never end. So give them orders.”

Hoo…

Chuck Hagel exhaled acrid cigar smoke and grinned.

“Start an all-out offensive against your enemies. Right now. Keep fighting until one side crumbles into the desert sand. Got it, you son of a bitch?”

“…!”

Facing Muhammad, whose eyes were wide with terror, Jin Taekyung pressed his hands together as if in prayer and added one more thing.

“From now on, kill each other.”

Muhammad finally understood. He had no choices left.

If he refused this final offer, all that awaited him was an agonizing, brutal death.

If I'd been a reasonably popular webnovel author, I could've gotten at least five episodes out of this.

Power struggles between terrorist groups large and small, political scenes, a few other ingredients thrown in for flavor—I could probably have stretched it to ten.

But I wasn't a webnovel author, and there were plenty of terrorist groups and rebel forces we needed to deal with right away.

In short, we had to run our asses off.

Kaboom!

Boom-boom-boom!

At first, we tried to handle things quietly. But the territory was vast and there were too few of us to cover it. Before long, we started getting a warm welcome.

And the single word *enemy* included a hail of gunfire and artillery shells, along with Awakened who called themselves "warriors of God."

"Kill them!"

"They're the ones who wiped out the mujahideen!"[2736]

"Thirty million dollars, paid immediately, to whoever captures or kills them!"

Shishshishshishk!

Dodging attacks raining down from every direction, I shouted in amazement.

"Wow, our bounty went up!"

"Shut up and dodge!"

"I think it was ten million yesterday. So *this* is why Luffy goes pirating!"

"Fucking shut up! Motherfuckeeer!"

"Fifty million! Let's hit fifty million! The Grand Line is just ahead!"

Sometimes we fought pitched battles. Other times, we slipped in like thieves in the night and wiped out a terrorist group or rebel force.

And when we reached the Grand Line—no, the desert—a living treasure was waiting for us.

"Leader of the Sooni faction. Omar al-Hussein, right?"

"It's Sunni, not Sooni."

"What are you talking about, you bastard who looks like Jeomsoon from the land steward's house?"[2737]

"Bastard…!"

"Hey, kid. Spring fists taste best in spring."

Crack!

[2736] *Mujahideen* is the plural of *mujahid*, a person who engages in jihad; the term is often used for armed fighters.

[2737] This alludes to Kim Yu-jeong's short story *Camellias*, which includes a line about spring potatoes. "Spring fists" substitutes fists for potatoes.

We didn’t stop. We fought across dozens of regions every day, capturing the leaders of terrorist groups and rebel forces or controlling them with Magic Johnson’s custom brainwashing Magic.

And just like that… a week passed in the blink of an eye.

Chapter 610

While dealing with armed terrorist groups and rebel forces in the Middle East, I came to realize two things.

First, there was no end to human malice.

Second, this horrific wheel would keep turning.

There were just too many bad people in the world.

They were weeds, plain and simple—viruses found everywhere on Earth. No matter how many you pulled out, more would grow somewhere else and make the world sick.

There was no way to stop this damn wheel forever.

Still, one thing is certain.

Even if I couldn't stop it forever, I could break it and bring it to a halt for a while.

And the old man sitting in front of me was one of the biggest parts keeping that enormous wheel turning.

"Hey there, young man in the strange mask."

The old man spoke calmly, stroking a teacup that gave off a strange scent with his wrinkled hand.

"Finding me was impressive, but… the world doesn't change that easily."

Al Diab Jawahiri—a man with a name as long as any other Arab's—remained calm despite the thunderous noises outside and the uninvited guest who had barged in.

He's clearly nothing more than a powerless old man.

I didn't know whether that remarkable composure came from more than a century of experience, or from the fact that he was the leader of Al-Qaeda, a colossal terrorist organization that divided control of the Middle East with ISIS.

What mattered was that he was wrong.

"It does change. People change, and someday the world will, too."

"Do you know how many Muslims bow before mighty Allah?"

"No. Other than the one sitting in front of me."

"Twenty-five percent, they say. Twenty-five percent of the entire world. That's over a billion people."

Al Diab smiled faintly and continued.

"You're fighting more than a billion Muslims. You've made mighty Allah and His servants your enemies."

The ramblings of a crazy old man weren't going to shake me. I smiled back.

"Not Muslims. Terrorists like you."

“I won’t deny that some of them still do not sympathize with us. It is a truly regrettable thing. But in the end, we are brothers. Bound together in the name of Allah, we will eventually gather beneath a single flag.”

“Is that why your ‘brothers’ split into Shiites and Sunnis[2738] and have spent centuries beating the hell out of each other?”

Al Diab answered without batting an eye.

“There is nothing strange about it. Husbands and wives. Brothers and sisters. Even within one household, people quarrel endlessly.”

“That’s because your family’s a complete mess. Mine isn’t.”

“What can one do? The conflict has been passed down from our ancestors. It is only a small dispute born of trivial misunderstandings and differences of opinion—a step on the way to becoming one.”

Al Diab didn’t understand. No, he didn’t want to understand in the slightest.

He didn’t understand how much suffering innocent people had endured because of those trivial misunderstandings and conflicts, and that hollow word *unity*.

Or how many countless people would suffer in the future.

Monster.

The old man before me was a monster, too. One consumed by twisted beliefs and stubborn conviction.

Then I saw a broad smile spread across his face, and a chill ran through me.

“What do you say, misguided young man? Why not put an end to this foolishness and join me?”

“…!”

“Your eyes are wavering. Your heart is shaken. Do not suffer while trapped by countless afflictions. Enter the warm embrace of Allah.”

His voice was perfectly serene as his deeply wrinkled hand reached slowly toward me.

I watched him with a faint tremor in my eyes, then let out a small sigh.

“Has living this long driven you out of your mind, old man…? What kind of shit are you trying to pull?”

“…!”

Shock flashed in his eyes.

“If you get caught trying something, you pay in blood. Pick one: neck or wrist.”

The instant our eyes met—

Shk! Bang!

Everything happened in an instant.

[2738] Shia and Sunni are the two main branches of Islam. Their division began over who should succeed the Prophet Muhammad as leader of the Muslim community.

The slender old man's wrist shot into the air, severed by the short sword I swung at the speed of a ray of light. At the same time, a bullet fired from a special firearm hidden deep inside his dark, voluminous sleeve pierced somewhere beyond my shoulder.

In short, I dodged. He didn't.

"Aaaaaaargh!"

Quite a set of lungs on the old man.

The scream was impossibly loud for someone well over a hundred years old. Clutching the stump of his cleanly severed wrist, Al Diab collapsed onto the carpet.

And then… another group moved even faster.

Shishshishshishk!

They emerged like ghosts from the ceiling, the walls, and beneath the carpet-covered floor. Beams of light and gusts of wind swirled from their hands.

Front, back, left, right—they surrounded me from all thirty-six directions[2739] and unleashed a terrifying assault.

But instead of dodging, I chose to attack.

Inventory open. Equip Fire Dragon Armor.

At the same instant—

Kakak! Ting-ting!

Aura tore through the air and struck the reddish armor, only to vanish. Blackened arrowheads bounced off it harmlessly.

Of course they did. Nothing short of the concentrated energy called Force or an Aura Blade could pierce the Fire Dragon Armor.

The men had the air of Murim assassins about them. I had no idea who had trained them, or how, but they realized the same thing immediately.

Whoosh!

No orders. Not even an exchanged glance.

The men in black turbans moved like machines following a programmed command. They abandoned my armored upper body and aimed for the exposed areas, including my lower body.

But the Fire Dragon Armor was a divine weapon capable of changing the course of a fight.

Against someone stronger than me, it could let me hold my own for a while. Against someone my equal, it could give me an overwhelming advantage.

And against people far weaker than me?

Thirty men? Even if ten times as many rushed me, they would be the ones to fall.

"Come on in, you crow bastards."

[2739] "Thirty-six directions" is a traditional martial-arts expression for every direction around a person, not literal compass points.

With that short taunt, I brought down the short sword in my hand.

Whoosh!

One horizontal strike was enough.

Kabooooom!

Superheated air erupted along the blade, melting Magic and weapons alike. The space around me warped.

As the mighty power that had lain dormant stretched and woke, the underground hideout shook from top to bottom.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The ground and ceiling weren't the only things shaking.

Several pairs of eyes visible between the black turbans quivered faintly.

Maybe it was because the men caught in my sword's path had died without so much as a final cry. Maybe they had felt the unbelievable gap in our strength.

Maybe it was both.

Either way, it was too late to retreat.

"Not coming? Then I'll come to you."

The word *outnumbered* had long since lost its meaning for me.

I had occasionally fought dozens of people, sometimes hundreds, and rarely even thousands—and I had survived every time.

The battle about to unfold here was nothing more than an extension of all the battles that had come before.

Shing!

A blade shot up from the ground and grazed my chin.

The patient one had never revealed himself, even while his comrades appeared one after another. But his attack had failed, and the price was death.

Crack!

I unleashed a grappling technique at lightning speed.

Before the man who had performed the bizarre feat of rotating his neck several times could collapse, I thrust out one hand.

Shishshik! Puk!

Five streams of Finger Qi cut through the air. Some of the crows launching themselves off the ceiling and walls fell.

The others who rushed in while leaving behind their comrade, whose neck had been pierced clean through, met much the same fate.

Fwooooooosh! Slash!

Their One Strike carried desperate resolve.

But the gap between will and ability was vast and deep.

My short sword split one man in two along with his sword. His body fell like a kite with its string cut.

Fwoosh! Boom!

I drove a palm strike at the blood spraying through the air. It evaporated in the terrible heat, and another attacker coming at me from beyond it flew backward even faster than he'd approached, slamming into the wall.

Boom!

The impact shook the room.

But even if the whole world had been turned upside down, their attacks wouldn't have stopped.

Whoosh!

Neck. Calf. Hand.

Three attacks whistled through the air at once, each aimed at a different target.

Instead of dodging, I stepped forward and swung the short sword in my hand.

No. I threw it.

Fwooooooosh! Crunch!

No one could survive with a Force-infused sword embedded in their heart.

The hilt slipped from its owner's hand as he died.

I reached for the two blades already closing in on me.

Grab!

Aura was an incredibly sharp and destructive concentration of energy. Cutting through bare hands imbued with Force was another matter.

I tightened my grip on the blades.

Grnk. Crack!

"…!"

"…!"

Two swords broke in half. Two pairs of eyes went wide with shock.

I said goodbye without a trace of emotion.

"Go."

"W-Wait…!"

"Oh, take these with you."

Had they ever given the people they killed time to say even one last word?

Maybe they had. I wasn't going to.

Puk!

"Guh!"

They let out gurgling cries as I drove their own broken blades into their chests.

The light faded from their eyes.

Thud.

The two bodies fell like rotten logs. I looked around.

No one else came at me. There was no more sound of attacks cutting through the air, no more death.

Only one man remained, staring at me in terror.

“Satan. You… you’re Satan.”

“Maybe. At least to people like you.”

Satan. I’d first heard the word from a deacon at church when I was little. By now, it felt almost as familiar as my own name.

I pulled the short sword from a corpse and approached Al Diab, muttering,

“Funny, isn’t it? The people who act more like demons than anyone else keep calling me Satan.”

“Y-You devil! Stay away from me! Evil Satan! Demon! In God’s name, begone!”

“…I’ve heard that a lot on Line 1.[2740] I’m suddenly getting homesick for a place I’ve never even missed.”

I was briefly wondering whether Al Diab had studied in Korea when the iron door leading outside opened. The noise beyond it had died away, and the Skeleton King appeared, covered in dust.

“Vile human. Are you finished?”

“Yeah. You?”

“I finished a little while ago. I’m getting ready to work. There’s no shortage of usable material, and I certainly have no objection, but… are you sure about this?”

“About what?”

“They’re human, like you. Your own kind. Using them for my Skeleton army might bother you…”

“They’re not my kind. Besides, this way I can go back to Korea with peace of mind.”

I answered without hesitation, then introduced the Skeleton King to Al Diab, who had frozen with his eyes wide open.

“Oh. This one’s an actual demon.”

“…!”

Fight barbarians with barbarians.

Barbarians should be dealt with by barbarians. Terrorists should be dealt with by what used to be terrorists.

I jabbed the Skeleton King in the side.

“Hey. Do it.”

“…I don’t want to.”

“Come on, don’t be like that. Do it already.”

[2740] Seoul Subway Line 1 is stereotypically associated with eccentric older passengers and their loud outbursts.

Looking less than pleased, he gave Al Diab a thumbs-up.
“Don’t worry! The undead army will take care of those piece-of-shit terrorists!”
Oh, I couldn’t resist that.

Chapter 611

"Allah[2741]! O great Allah!"

"Deal with him, Satan."

"Goodbye, vile human."

I left Al Diab, who was screaming loud enough to split the heavens, in the Skeleton King's hands and turned away. Whatever happened after that was no longer my concern.

If he had been the leader of some run-of-the-mill terrorist organization, there would have been nothing left to discuss—I would have executed him on the spot. But the leader of Al-Qaeda was another matter entirely. Magic Johnson or the Skeleton King would probably find a way to put him to good use. Whether through Magic or some kind of divine power.

Maybe I should have learned the Soul-Seizing Technique.

I felt a twinge of regret.

The Soul-Seizing Technique bewitched and controlled people. It was classified among the demonic, heterodox arts, but there were people in the orthodox faction who had learned it. The same went for the disguise technique.

I hadn't learned either one. Not because I didn't need them—I'd just been too busy putting on a tearful shitshow trying to stay alive.

Come to think of it, there's a practitioner of demonic, heterodox arts nearby...

I wasn't sure whether that guy had learned the Soul-Seizing Technique. If I got the chance, maybe I could learn a few techniques from him that might prove useful in the future.

While I was thinking about matters in the Murim, the enormous underground hideout, which resembled a giant anthill, finally came to an end. An endless sandy desert filled my field of vision.

Beneath the glittering stars, a man puffing thick clouds of cigar smoke opened his mouth in a rough voice.

"Back already? That was quicker than I expected. Did you catch Al Diab?"

I looked over the bodies of the terrorists scattered around him and answered.

"Yes. I left him with the Skeleton King."

"Allah's faithful servant, in the hands of a monster. Good. Damn old bastard. I'd have liked to see his face."

"He didn't seem to like it very much. He's probably still screaming and calling him Satan."

Chuck Hagel laughed with satisfaction.

[2741] *Allah* is the Arabic word for God.

He'd learned the Skeleton King's true identity three days ago. In the short conversation that followed, he'd proved that he thought nothing like an ordinary person.

"Undead?"

"Yes."

"Is Undead his last name? Because I could've sworn you called him Stone King earlier."

"No. Undead is his gender. Wait, not gender—species."

"You said he was from Georgia."

"Surprise. He's actually the Skeleton King from the Demon Realm."

"So he's a monster."

"Yes."

"Hey, motherfucker. Are you kidding me? Why is there a monster here—"

"Technically, an undead monster. A named undead monster, to be even more precise."

"…Are you people out of your minds? What the hell are you doing?"

"He's a monster, but he saved my life from an Arch Lich during the Small Cataclysm."

"What?"

"Oh, and he helped suppress more than ten Mutated Gates and three Gate Waves in Korea."

"Holy shit. So he's a war veteran. Welcome, undead warrior."

Black cat or white cat.

People said it didn't matter whether a cat was black or white as long as it caught mice. Even so, Chuck Hagel's way of thinking was truly extraordinary.

My grandfather was a goddamn Indian-killer who even received medals. But I don't give a fuck about that. If someone can deal with fucking terrorists and Gates and has the heart to devote themselves to helping people, what does skin color matter?

"Chuck. He doesn't have skin."

"Don't care what color his bones are, either."

Chuck Hagel's willingness to look past not just race but species was enough to make my heart swell. He even showed an ambition I could hardly believe coming from the Secretary of Defense of the United States.

"I won't tell the President."

"I was hoping you'd say that, Chuck, but… can you really do that?"

"He didn't ask."

"Oh."

"That's how the military works. If you don't get caught, it's fine. Write 'military,' read it as 'sham.'"

Of course, that was complete nonsense. How could a country's Secretary of Defense know something like this and keep quiet just because the President hadn't asked?

But it was also the sort of crazy thing Chuck Hagel could get away with. Uncle Chuck was, along with Magic Johnson, a symbol of the United States. The legendary war heroes born from the Great Cataclysm had been granted tremendous love and affection—along with an unspoken free pass.

Even with that free pass, it's still crazy. Hm.

Fortunately, Chuck Hagel had done crazy things often enough.

I looked at him warmly.

"What's with that look?"

"I just really like you, Chuck."

"Was that why you were so close to Johnson?"

"…That's how you took it? Come to think of it, where are the other two?"

I hadn't seen Team Leader Choi or Magic Johnson anywhere nearby. Chuck Hagel chewed on his cigar as he answered.

"They're investigating the Gate. These bastards even had a secret Magic Gem laboratory."

A secret laboratory. I'd half expected it.

A middling terrorist group might not have had the resources, but Al-Qaeda carried out attacks around the world. It had people and supplies to spare. A Magic Gem laboratory cost an astronomical amount to run, but finding one here wasn't much of a surprise.

"How big?"

"Bigger than we expected. Choi and Johnson think it was built at least ten years ago."

"Ten years?"

"Yes. I don't know whether they conducted other experiments here before this, or whether they were planning terrorist attacks using Magic Gems, as we feared… But it's clear that they've been plotting something for quite a long time."

"Hmm."

Apparently Go Jun hadn't been the first to think of using Magic Gems to kill people. Given that Al-Qaeda was a terrorist organization, that wasn't exactly surprising.

"Did they get anywhere? Have they found something?"

"Who knows? We'll have to squeeze the terrorist researchers for answers. But if they'd achieved anything, I imagine an even bigger incident would already have happened."

"That's true."

“At the very least, the terrorist attacks that took place in Texas and elsewhere this time have little to do with Al-Qaeda. If it had been them, they would have already obtained data through human experimentation. They would have had no reason to put on such a stupid show of suicide.”

He had a point. If the attacks had succeeded, that might have been different. But Al-Qaeda had no reason to throw away valuable Hunters and Magic Gems on a suicide show that only advertised their stupidity. It wasn’t a banzai charge[2742] or a kamikaze attack[2743].

They would just attract a whole lot of attention and get beaten to a pulp.

As I thought that, Chuck Hagel spoke again.

“Lately, I’ve found myself thinking about something. Maybe it’s impossible to completely eradicate these bastards. Maybe that’s something we’ll never be able to do.”

He looked unusually drained today. The cigar he had been holding in his mouth was extended toward me.

“I don’t smoke.”

“I know. The point is, this goddamn American military cigar was in their possession.”

I muttered quietly.

“They have someone on the inside?”

“If it had only been the cigar, I wouldn’t have said anything. But… there was enough to fill a mountain. Food, experimental equipment, medical equipment, advanced missiles, even artifacts. Most of it was the kind of material that couldn’t be taken overseas without approval from the Ministry of National Defense.”

I firmly patted his shoulder as he muttered bitterly.

“Cheer up, Chuck. It’s not the first time, is it? And it’s not as if you didn’t know.”

“Hah. That’s comforting.”

As we had destroyed more than a few dozen terrorist organizations, the only things we had seen weren’t corpses and pools of blood. What we had seen most nakedly was the shameful face of the world.

How did they get all that stuff? Who gave it to them?

Military officials? Senior politicians? Black-market dealers who’d do anything for money? Maybe all of them.

I didn’t know. But one thing was certain: someone was watering the weeds we needed to pull out by the roots.

“Bastards.”

[2742] A *banzai charge* was a mass infantry assault associated with Japanese forces during World War II.

[2743] *Kamikaze* refers to Japanese suicide attacks, particularly those carried out by pilots during World War II.

Chuck Hagel hurled his cigar into the distance. Its faint ember vanished in the cold darkness of the desert. He watched it disappear, then spoke on a sigh.

"Crazy Korean. What are you going to do now?"

The sudden question pulled me from my thoughts, but I answered calmly. I had already made up my mind several days ago.

"I'm going back."

"To South Korea? Well, it couldn't be North Korea, so I suppose that's right."

"Hard to say."

Half right, half wrong. I neither confirmed nor denied it, only shrugged.

Chuck Hagel smiled ruefully.

"Right. You can't keep playing masked vigilante in that ridiculous getup forever."

"Hmm. I wouldn't call it particularly ridiculous."

"You serious? Is it a South Korean fashion thing?"

I let out a quiet laugh.

"I didn't mean to us."

"Hm?"

"The rebels and terrorists. How do you think it looks to them?"

"…!"

Chuck Hagel's mouth closed tightly.

I looked up at the night sky, crowded with constellations I couldn't name.

"The Mujahideen. Al-Qaeda. ISIS's Syrian branch…"

I recited the names of the major terrorist groups whose leaders and headquarters we'd destroyed over the past week, then the names of the smaller groups we'd uprooted entirely.

"We haven't dealt with all of them, but we've sent a clear warning."

They didn't know our names or ages, let alone our nationalities or what we looked like.

We wore masks, avoided surveillance with Magic Johnson's Magic, and fought while changing our weapons and combat methods.

And…

"Nothing's scarier than an enemy you can't identify."

In just one week, we'd become something terrorist organizations feared. They couldn't catch us, even with enormous bounties on our heads. Without knowing who we were, they couldn't use their favorite tactic against us: retaliatory attacks.

On top of that, several leaders of some of the world's most notorious international terrorist organizations had already died at our hands or been controlled into starting internal conflicts.

"If they don't want the same thing to happen to them, they'll keep their heads down."

A weak deterrent invited defiance. Overwhelming force inspired fear.

The prisoners we'd freed had already stood before microphones and cameras to tell the world what they'd seen and suffered. Once again, the international community was burning like a furnace—over the horrors unfolding around the world, and over us.

"Given time, things will get a little better."

The weed called malice sprouts first in a person's heart. People who harbor it go on to do evil.

But what could you do? You couldn't pull every weed out of every heart. You *could* pull out the weeds you could see.

"It's not about how many weeds you pull. It's about how many people pull them together. You and me, Chuck. Like we did."

One person could pull one. Someone else, two. Or three.

If everyone paid attention and did their part, wouldn't the weeds eventually disappear? I'd only recently come to that small but profound realization.

"Well, that's what I think, anyway."

Had I been talking too much? I let the silence settle. Chuck Hagel studied me with an odd expression, then spoke.

"Hey. Can I ask you something?"

"Anything."

"I didn't get an answer earlier… Where exactly are you going back to? Judging by what you just said, it sounds like you should at least be going to the Vatican."

I laughed quietly.

"It's hard to explain. Somewhere like this."

"Where, Afghanistan?"

"Farther than that. Much farther."

"…Much farther?"

Chuck Hagel looked bewildered, and my smile deepened despite myself.

Yes. It was time to go back.

After I took care of the one thing I'd put off until the very end.

Chapter 612

"Come out."

His voice was low and steady, his eyes glinting sharply in the dark.

I watched him without answering. After a brief silence, a click sounded and the living room lit up.

The man took a cautious step forward and spoke again, putting more force into his voice.

"I know you're hiding. Come out. Do you know who I am?"

Of course I did. I knew his name and face, even his age and hometown. I just hadn't expected him to pull this the moment I came home.

"All right, last chance. If you don't come out by the time I count to three, I'm calling a younger buddy of mine. He's a really strong, successful Hunter. One. Two…"

I was curious about what would happen after he counted to three, but after seeing everything there was to see, continuing to watch felt embarrassing.

I spoke with a sigh.

"Don't tell me that close younger friend is me?"

"…!"

"Well, would you look at that. Guess I was right."

Jinho stood frozen like a statue, staring at me with his eyes wide.

"Wh-What? Why are you coming out of there?"

"I knew you were going to call me anyway, so I came early. Happy?"

Jinho fell silent for a moment, then asked with a grave expression, "How much did you see?"

"From 'Come out.'"

"Ah, fuck…"

"You looked cool. Your presence was so overwhelming I almost came out without being asked."

"Are you making fun of me?"

"Yeah."

Jinho stared at me after that shameless answer, then let out a quiet laugh.

"You bastard. You haven't changed at all."

Why did those few words make me so glad to see him? So grateful?

I smiled back. "I'm hungry. Make me some ramyeon.[2744]"

[2744] *Ramyeon* is Korean instant noodles.

Sitting across from each other with a steaming pot between us felt like going back a year.

Of course, we'd both changed a lot since then.

"First time I've seen you in a suit, hyung.[2745] You used to wear nothing but those ragged tracksuits."

"Hey, they weren't ragged. That's a pretty expensive brand."

"When did you buy them?"

"Hmm. High school?"

How old had Jinho hyung been then? After thinking for a moment, I nodded.

"So they weren't *like* rags. They were rags. Get me some water. No, wait. Got any soju?[2746]"

"You might as well walk into a barbecue restaurant and ask if they have meat."

"…At this rate, you're going to die young."

"I would've quit ages ago if it weren't for that asshole Section Chief Kim. That fucking bastard isn't even that far from me in age, but he picks fights over every little thing and acts like a complete jackass."

Jinho yanked his tie loose and downed three shots of soju in a row.

Late last year, he'd finally passed the civil service exam he'd spent so long preparing for.

"So you really did become a civil servant. The world's coming to an end."

"Listen to this bastard. You thought I wouldn't?"

"No. Becoming one is beside the point. I thought you'd drop dead in the act while watching porn before you ever got there."

"…Hmm. That's actually a fair point."

The fact that he didn't deny it meant he still had a shred of conscience.

If the government had a Ministry of Porn, he could have risen all the way to minister. With Sora Aoi[2747] as deputy minister and Asuka Kirara[2748] as spokesperson, he'd have ruled Pornhub.

Unfortunately, no such deranged ministry existed. Instead, Jinho had passed a special recruitment exam and been assigned to the Hunter and Gate Management Department, known as a plum posting.

I suspected our friendship had earned him a few invisible bonus points.

Glug, glug, glug.

Jinho filled his glass to the brim, then asked, "What brings you here?"

[2745] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older man with whom he is close.

[2746] *Soju* is a Korean alcoholic spirit commonly served in small glasses.

[2747] Sora Aoi is a Japanese former adult-film performer.

[2748] Asuka Kirara is a Japanese former adult-film performer.

“In case you’ve forgotten, this is my place. Though lately I can’t tell if it’s an officetel[2749] or a garbage dump.”

“I’m asking because the owner hasn’t shown his face in over two or three months, you punk.”

“Well, I came to see you. And there’s something I need to pick up.”

“Pick up? If it’s clothes, just buy some. You’ve got money coming out of your ears.”

“Money won’t help. Nobody sells it.”

“What is it?”

Jinho looked puzzled, then gave a short exclamation.

“Oh. That old capsule?”

“Yeah. Good thing you didn’t throw it away.”

“You said you’d kill me if I did.”

“That’s why it’s a good thing. I really would’ve had to kill you. Phew.”

“…You’re joking, right? Please tell me you’re joking.”

The game capsule that had first led me to the Murim had sat here unused ever since the System allowed me to Login and Logout freely without it.

But that didn’t make it a piece of junk I could toss aside. That old capsule had done more than anything else to make me who I was. It was priceless.

“I don’t wipe the dining table, but I wipe that capsule down once a week,” Jinho said. “It still doesn’t work, though. Why take it?”

“Just because. For decoration, I guess.”

“Isn’t that thing haunted? Remember when you lived at Hope Goshiwon?[2750] You slept in it and had some weird nightmare…”

Oh. That had happened, hadn’t it?

Jinho was bringing up my first Logout. I hurried to change the subject.

“Did you see the news? Things got pretty crazy in the Middle East and Afghanistan.”

“Huh? Where did that come from?”

“I’m asking if you saw it.”

“Of course I did. Yesterday the Middle Eastern terrorist groups and the Afghan rebels even issued a joint statement. Said they’d refrain from terrorism and keep their men in line from now on. Basically surrendered because they got scared.”

“Don’t let your guard down. It’ll only last a little while.”

“Still, those five weirdos in masks are incredible, aren’t they?”

The change of subject seemed to have worked. I breathed an inward sigh of relief and nodded.

[2749] An *officetel* is a Korean building type combining office and residential units.

[2750] A *goshiwon* is a Korean lodging house offering small, usually furnished rooms. The name comes from their use by people studying for civil-service exams.

"They are."

"Well, anyway."

Jinho slurped up his noodles, washed them down with soju, and went on.

"You've had it rough. A Monster Wave right after the new year, humans worse than monsters, and now trips to the desert and Africa."

"What do you mean, rough? It was just something I had to do…"

I suddenly faltered and let the end of the sentence trail off.

Wait. What the hell had he just said?

"Sorry, what?"

"What you heard. I took a shot in the dark, and it looks like I was more or less right."

"…!"

"Come on. How many people in the world could do something like that? Everyone says they wish the terrorists would die and they never want to see those rebel bastards again. But who'd actually put on a mask and do something about it? More to the point, who *could*?"

Jinho gave a quiet laugh at my wide-eyed stare.

"Some people have probably guessed, too, but they're keeping quiet. There's no evidence, and it's not as if they have any reason to blame you. But one low-ranking civil servant happens to know what kind of person the masked man is—and even shares ramyeon with him—so he can casually sound him out like this."

I rubbed the back of my head, which somehow felt numb.

I had suspected I would be named as a prime suspect, but I hadn't expected to get caught this absurdly easily.

"I-I'm really not him."

"Sure. Let's say you aren't. When did you get back?"

"…"

Damn it. There was no saving this.

I sighed, filled my soju glass, and answered. "Three days ago. No, four."

"Good. Now you're cooperating."

"Don't tell anyone. Never mind that it's classified—you'd be in danger."

Team Leader Choi, my family, and I were always surrounded by protection no one could see. Jinho wasn't.

He understood what I meant immediately and smacked his lips.

"Hmm. I feel like a big shot."

"You might get a bomb delivered before you become one."

"Maybe. But even if they all know, they won't be able to touch me, will they? They won't know what Jin Taekyung might do if he completely loses it. Hah, isn't this what you call Untouchable?"

Jinho laughed without a care, then asked, “Anyway, how busy have you been? You can’t even remember when you got back.”

“Hmm.”

How busy?

I scratched at the beard that had grown thick before I knew it.

“I train day and night. Eat with my family, then train some more.”

“Train? Why does someone at your level need to train?”

“You graduated from a prestigious university and still spent nearly ten more years studying. Same thing.”

“You bastard, going straight for the sore spot. Besides, how are we the same? It’s not just a different field—we’re on completely different levels.”

He had a point. His prestigious university admitted hundreds of students every year, and about as many graduated.

But I still needed training.

There was no end to learning, and *gongbu*—study—wasn’t limited to academics.

To be precise, I’m not learning something new. I’m slowly going back over what I already know.

In that sense, my training was a kind of review. Study for my own sake, and for the sake of this world.

Unfortunately, I still hadn’t managed to bring it all together.

“Ugh, look at that serious expression. It makes me want to slap you in the cheek.”

“…I’m in the middle of being serious, so could you shut that mouth of yours?”

“Put yourself in my shoes. What would you do?”

“Hmm. Fair enough. Have a drink.”

We clinked glasses. Jinho knocked back his soju, poked at the noodles that had gone cold, and asked, “So? Is the training going well?”

“More or less. I started preparing about a month ago, so I’m nearly done, but… it’s not easy.”

I wasn’t exaggerating.

I was like a child trying to assemble a ten-thousand-piece puzzle. As I checked each piece and fit them together, I felt my own shortcomings and regretted what I lacked. Now, unable to find the final piece, I was groping around in the dark.

And I already knew the name of the darkness obscuring my sight.

The heart demon.

The dark cloud over my heart refused to clear. My worries about the Murim and the modern world… and, more than anything, the last sight of Kim Hwajong kept returning to me.

His voice, which seemed as though it could fade away at any moment.

His eyes slowly closing in the red snowfield covered with blood.

Maybe I hadn't come here for the capsule after all. Maybe I'd come to find some comfort.

Not with the family I loved or the companions at my side, but with a friend living his own life in a completely different world. Maybe I'd just wanted to clink glasses with him like we used to.

Yeah. That was it.

All at once, I felt more at ease.

I hadn't shaken off the heart demon entirely, but acknowledging everything that had happened—and everything that troubled me—lifted some of the weight from my heart.

I also realized that I wasn't where I needed to be.

"I'm leaving."

"The ramyeon's cold. I was going to make tofu kimchi[2751] to go with the drinks… Wait, now?"

"Yeah. I remembered something I have to do. Drink by yourself."

"Are you crazy?"

"No. I'm your landlord. Want to start paying rent this month?"

Jinho hyung, who had been glaring at me fiercely, immediately bent deeply at the waist.

"Get home safely, Boss."

"Will do."

I laughed quietly and headed for the front door. Behind me, Jinho called out in a rush.

"Hey! What about the capsule?"

"Next time. I'll take it next time."

Even as I said it, I knew that next time, I might give him the same answer and leave the capsule where it was. I might come only to clink glasses with him, just as I had today.

"All right. Hang in there, you bastard."

Someone's quiet murmur reached my ears as I walked on.

[2751] *Tofu kimchi* is a Korean dish of tofu served with kimchi, often as a drinking snack.

Chapter 613

The Training Room was silent again today.

Countless kinds of weapons lay strewn across the floor, and the walls—enchanted with automatic restoration magic—had been reduced to a miserable ruin.

At the center of it all… I sat cross-legged, lost in thought.

More. Just a little more.

I was almost there.

The final piece of this enormous puzzle.

Right after parting ways with Jinho hyung[2752], I had shut myself in the Training Room and begun the last stretch of work to find it.

Even if the stress made all my hair fall out, even if the worst happened and I risked qi deviation, I had to get through it.

No matter what it took, I had to complete this puzzle before I left.

For the future.

I had only started searching for the final piece recently, but I'd decided to put the puzzle together months ago. It was probably after the battle with the Arch Lich—the incident dubbed the Small Cataclysm.

If this keeps up, everyone will be in danger.

The thought had come to me out of nowhere one day. As time passed, my unease turned into certainty.

Magical power levels had risen abnormally. Monsters had grown stronger, and human casualties—which had fallen dramatically after the Great Cataclysm—were once again mounting everywhere.

Humanity needed another kind of power. After a great deal of thought, I made my decision.

I would create martial arts.

I would give them a new sword and shield against the dangers and disasters growing by the day.

Of course, it was anything but easy. What I created had to be safe enough for even the lowest-rank Hunter to learn, yet limited enough in power that evildoers couldn't exploit it.

But… at last, I found the final piece of the puzzle.

Yes. This is it.

After hundreds of attempts, I had found a single path.

The moment I completed the still-unnamed cultivation technique—

Ding. Ding. Ding.

[2752] *Hyung* is a Korean term used by a man for an older brother or an older male friend.

As if congratulating me, a series of lively alerts rang out.

Team Leader Choi—or rather, Choi Minwoo, now Guild Master of the Peace Guild and Vice Guild Master of Ares Guild—was so busy he barely had time to breathe.

During the week he'd been away, the matters awaiting his attention had multiplied into the hundreds. His temporary personal secretary was sweating bullets as calls from powerful figures poured in.

"G-Guild Master. The Blue House has proposed a luncheon."

"Political figures and the Federation of Korean Industries would like you to attend a social gathering…"

"The Guild Alliance has proposed a partnership on Gate-related business…"

"Regarding the establishment of overseas branches…"

Some invitations couldn't be refused. Others easily could. Choi Minwoo's answer was always the same.

"All right. Schedule it."

He followed a schedule planned down to the minute, spending each day like a machine and barely sleeping. The people around him watched his punishing routine with concern.

"Okay, pick one. Team Leader Choi, Guild Master Choi, or Vice Guild Master Choi. What should we call you?"

"Please call me Team Leader Choi. That's what I was when we met."

"All right, then. Team Leader Choi, I'll be direct… Get some rest. Cut back your schedule and leave the little things to your secretary."

"She's right, Team Leader Choi. You may be young, but you can't keep this up without wearing yourself out."

"I'm fine. Please don't worry, either of you."

"Team Leader Choi."

"No, listen…"

As for me, I'm fine.

His voice was calm, and his answer never changed. Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong, who had tried to talk him out of it, could only fall silent.

The answer that reached their ears was the same as before, but the answer that reached their hearts was different.

As for me, I'm fine.

Choi Minwoo left them with that one phrase, the same and yet different, and continued burying himself in work.

He even dismissed the personal secretary who had been helping him a little, then plunged into days busier than ever.

So it was hardly surprising when the subject came up during a private meeting with President Baek Hanseong.

“You seem very busy these days.”

“That’s why I like it.”

“I hear you don’t even have a secretary anymore. Is there a particular reason?”

“Coffee.”

“Pardon?”

“She couldn’t make coffee. That’s all.”

President Baek Hanseong assumed it was a joke and laughed it off, but every answer Choi Minwoo had given him was sincere.

Choi Minwoo liked being buried in work so completely, and the coffee made by his young secretary had been strangely awful.

More than that, he was grateful to forget, if only for a little while, the longing and grief for someone who kept coming to mind.

“Enough idle talk from me. Let’s move on to the next item.”

One day passed. Then another.

While Jin Taekyung trained in an isolated space, Choi Minwoo isolated himself amid countless people.

Perhaps that was why, one day, a name suddenly came to mind. As he drove himself mercilessly hard, just as he always did, the longing he had buried deep inside rose to the surface.

“Driver Jung, turn the car around.”

“Pardon? I’m sorry, but I believe our next appointment is at…”

“Cancel everything today. There’s somewhere I need to go.”

The driver’s startled eyes met his in the rearview mirror. Choi Minwoo sank back into the limousine seat.

Warm spring air and sunlight came through the half-open window as he headed to meet someone.

Step. Step.

The hill he climbed alone was high and steep, and his footsteps were heavy. Or perhaps it was his heart.

Sorrow and guilt over the one person he could never reach, even if he climbed this high, steep path a hundred or a thousand times, weighed on Choi Minwoo’s heart.

Pluck. Pluck.

Along the way, he picked an armful of early spring flowers. The pure white violets didn’t seem like enough, so he added scarlet moss phlox from the clusters growing beside the path.

The man who was no longer by his side had always said he liked red.

And yet he always wore black suits.

It was only recently that Choi Minwoo had learned what color he liked most, and why he had sold all those motorcycles.

Why he had quit drinking despite once keeping alcohol so close, and why he had trimmed the shaggy beard and long hair he had grown out before neatly parting it.

Why did you do all that? You were enough for me.

He knew everything now, but he had learned it all too late.

With an ache in his chest, Choi Minwoo kept walking.

On the warm, breezy hilltop, a large burial mound awaited him, and the three characters carved into the granite gravestone stood out with unusual clarity.

The late Kim Hwajong.

What could he say?

Choi Minwoo stared at the old butler, laid to rest on this warm hill instead of a cold, snow-covered mountain. At last, he opened his mouth.

"I'm here."

His usually steady eyes trembled. He bit down on his trembling lip and slowly went on.

"…Grandfather."

The word he had held in his heart, but never once said while the old man was alive, finally escaped him.

Whoosh—

A wind swept over him from somewhere. The grass on the hill bent low, and the branches waved.

Choi Minwoo set his bouquet beside the mound. Then he froze.

What's that?

His eyes widened. He was looking at the back of the gravestone.

Words he had never noticed before were carved there.

> You came.
> Thank you, and I love you.
> Be happy.

"…!"

Who had carved them? He should have wondered, but right now, it didn't matter.

Choi Minwoo stood frozen like a stone statue, staring endlessly at the short message.

His heart shook like flowers in the wind. Something rose from deep inside him, closing his throat and making his eyes burn.

"Ah."

Overwhelmed, he let out a choked sigh.

“You came sooner than I expected. I thought I’d have to wait at least a few more days.”

A voice sounded behind him.

Choi Minwoo turned. Someone stood there holding a small box.

It was the Skeleton King.

Why was he here? What did he mean, *wait*?

The questions vanished as quickly as they came. What Choi Minwoo needed now wasn’t a reason, but warmth. An answer to a question he couldn’t resolve alone.

“May I ask you one thing? Just one?”

Normally, the Skeleton King would have curtly said no. This time, he readily nodded.

“Anything.”

“If it were Mr. Jin Taekyung… what would he do at a time like this?”

The Skeleton King understood the sudden question at once.

“Why do you ask?”

“Because he’s stronger than anyone I know.”

The Skeleton King stared at Choi Minwoo in silence before answering in a low voice.

“He would have cried. Without a doubt.”

“…!”

“And then he would overcome it and go on living, forever remembering the person who left.”

That was enough.

Choi Minwoo let the tears he had held back fall. With them, he let out his grief and regret, his longing and guilt.

The Skeleton King quietly stepped away. It would be better to give him the contents of the box a little later.

He remembered what Jin Taekyung had said when he entrusted him with it about half a day ago.

“Sorry, but I need a favor.”

“No. I refuse. Go away.”

“Give this to Team Leader Choi. No one else.”

“You damnable human. Now you’re not even pretending to listen. Do I look like an errand boy to you?”

“I’m not asking because you’re an errand boy. I’m asking because I trust you.”

“…What exactly am I supposed to give him?”

“Martial arts.”

"What?"

"He'll understand when you tell him. There's a letter in the box, too. Make sure he reads it."

"No. How am I supposed to find someone I haven't even seen lately…?"

"Wait at Butler Kim's grave. Even if you see him before then, don't say a word. He'll probably need time to get through this."

No matter how the Skeleton King looked at it, Jin Taekyung was a strange human.

For one thing, Choi Minwoo had arrived at the grave just as Taekyung had said he would.

And he was even stranger for the fact that once he fell asleep, he would not so much as blink even if someone grabbed him by the collar and shook him awake.

Damn him. He has the nerve to give me a petty errand like this while he sleeps without a care?

Jin Taekyung had repeatedly begged him not to wake him under any circumstances, so he was probably dead asleep by now.

The more the Skeleton King thought about Jin Taekyung, the more infuriating he found him. But honestly, for some strange reason, he did not feel all that bad.

I can entrust it to you because I trust you. Trust, huh? Hmm. Hmmm.

The Skeleton King nodded as he remembered the box in his hands and Jin Taekyung's words, then muttered quietly.

"…Sweet dreams, you devious human."

Whoosh—

The wind blew once more. It swallowed one man's sobs and the voice of a monster who had, before he knew it, grown close to people.

Chapter 614

SYSTEM

Synchronization begins. 10, 9, 8, 7… 1, 0.
Synchronization completed successfully. Updated stats have been applied to the body. The use of certain Titles is restricted.
Login complete.

Ding.

Before the familiar System notifications had even finished, I felt rough straw against my skin and smelled wet grass.

I spat out the piece of rice straw stuck to my lips and muttered inwardly.

I'm back.

Back in the Murim.

I'd spent barely over a month in the modern world, yet my time here felt like the distant past. It wasn't just my imagination.

I've had way too much going on.

The Murim. The modern world.

Everything around me in both worlds was changing fast. One thing kept happening after another. Even two bodies wouldn't have been enough to keep up.

"…"

Come to think of it, I *did* have two bodies. Having to control them one at a time was what made it so damn exhausting.

Anyway…

Ah. I don't want to get up.

The straw covering me was warmer and softer than I'd expected. I wanted nothing more than to lie there and sleep. I'd barely slept for nearly a week while developing a martial art for widespread use.

I might have drifted off if I hadn't heard voices nearby.

"Hmm. You're asking what kind of person Captain is?"

"Yes. I've been curious for a while. The other two aren't here yet, and I'm bored. You're curious too, aren't you, Escort Song?"

I knew those voices. After Hyuk Mujin and Ju Hwaran, Song Ilseom—the Soul-Chasing Guest—answered gruffly.

"Not particularly."

"Did you hear that? Escort Song is curious too."

"I said I'm not."

"I'll give you two more silver nyang[2753]."

"…I'm a little curious."

Money-grubbing bastard.

Once Song Ilseom had been won over by the big spender's silver donation, Mujin spoke again, sounding hesitant.

"Hmm. This is hard to answer. Captain's definitely still asleep, right?"

"Yes. Yes."

"He is. His breathing is steady."

"Well, once he falls asleep, he wouldn't notice if a ghost carried him away."

Steady, my ass.

I was controlling my breathing. I was curious what Mujin would say, too.

And my loyal right pinky toe didn't let me down.

"Our captain is that famous, really famous… uh, how do I put it…?"

"A handsome, impressive young prodigy?"

At Ju Hwaran's question, delivered in a voice as clear and lovely as a Young Chang piano, Hyuk Mujin answered without a trace of hesitation.

"He was a fucking bastard."

"…Ah."

"…Uh."

"These days, people call him the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon and all that. But a year or two ago, you'd have had a hard time finding a bigger fucking bastard. He went to pleasure houses and got shit-faced every day, stole public funds, and blew them at gambling dens. He was so bad that his sobriquet back then was…"

"Hey."

"That's right. The Night King. In that field, even all Ten Kings together wouldn't have been a match for him. Every night, he'd strap a money pouch to his side and stride off to a pleasure house like he owned the place. My fellow gate guards and I used to say, 'That fucking bastard's using the Heavenly Demon Reign Step again.' I see you've heard of him, Great Hero Song. You really do know a lot."

"What are you talking about?" Song Ilseom asked, sounding uneasy. "I didn't say anything."

"What?"

"I didn't say anything."

"Come on. You said 'hey' just now."

"No, I didn't."

"It was definitely a man's voice. Don't joke around. Then who…?"

His voice cut off.

[2753] A nyang was a traditional Korean unit of currency; here, the amount is specified in silver.

After a short, heavy silence, someone carefully lifted the straw from my face.

Rustle. Ssshh.

The straw blocking my view fell away. In the faint moonlight, my eyes met Mujin's.

I gave him a warm, friendly smile. It had been a while.

"Hey."

"…"

Mujin stared down at me in silence, his gaze growing somber. Then he laid the straw back over my face.

Very carefully, as though nothing had happened.

"Move it."

"The moon must be bright tonight. I'm hearing things…"

"If you don't move it, your life's going to get dark. Move it."

"Yes, sir."

The straw had stopped feeling warm and cozy.

Like a vampire waking after centuries sealed away by an exorcist, I rose from the wagon's cargo bed.

Whoooosh.

A chilly wind blew the bits of straw from my clothes.

Ju Hwaran met my eyes and hastily looked away. By the campfire—when had he even lit that?—Song Ilseom got to his feet, muttering that he needed to feed the horse some hay.

My shadow swelled in the flickering firelight and fell across Mujin.

"Any last words?"

"Captain, please. Hear me out."

"That's why I asked."

"You said they were my last words. It sounds like a will."

"It probably is."

"…Ah."

"You were having a great time. As your captain, I can't tell you how happy it makes me to see my subordinate enjoying himself."

That was half true. I really couldn't contain myself.

I'd busted my ass in the Murim, busted my ass in the modern world, and come back without getting any sleep—only to find my own subordinate talking shit about me behind my back.

And the name of the emotion that followed this situation straight out of a light novel was rage.

"Face, arms, legs, abdomen, back. Pick one."

"Are those my possible causes of death?"

“I’m not going to kill you. I’m just going to beat you within an inch of your life.”

Mujin thought for a moment.

“The abdomen.”

“Why?”

“Wounds on the back are… a martial artist’s shame.”

I let out an exclamation at his spirit.

“What a load of bullshit.”

“I did wrong, so I’ll take my punishment. Come at me.”

“Since you picked your abdomen, I’ll pick the rest.”

“What?”

“What do you mean, ‘what’? It wouldn’t be fair if only you got to choose. I should get a turn too.”

“No, wait. How is that fair—”

Wham!

The blow cracked through the night.

Above the slowly burning campfire, the shadow of a man soaring upward with blood spraying from his nose loomed large.

I’m already using my fists the moment I get back.

We were on Mount Daebyeol, where Anhui and Hubei bordered Henan.

Two figures approached from the distance, with Mujin’s screams providing the background music. They were the final members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion: a pair of rootless unorthodox faction nobodies.

“…Why are they beating him?”

“Taishan! Is here!”

At last, the Fire Dragon Pavilion’s Nanman expedition party had gathered in one place. I left them with a short but powerful lecture, then turned away.

“All right, let’s finish beating this bastard and get going.”

Nobody objected.

Right now, I wasn’t Jin Taekyung the S-rank Hunter. I was the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, the orthodox Murim’s greatest young prodigy, and Jin Taekyung, Fire Dragon Pavilion Master—their direct superior.

Crack!

“Urgh! Aaaagh!”

I really do love the Murim. Except for that damned Dark Heaven.

Not a single ray of light reached that pitch-black place.

In the darkness, where neither sound nor any sign of life could be felt, figures lay facedown and trembled.

Then—

“Heaven above, earth below!”

“All demons bow in submission!”

The cries erupted as one, thunderous. Crimson-black flames surged up from the darkness.

Fwoosh!

A ring of fire blazed fiercely. Yet despite being unmistakable flames, they gave off a chill that seeped into the bones. Beyond them, someone’s shadow wavered.

“It has been a long time.”

Man or woman, young or old—even the pitch of the voice was impossible to tell.

The strange voice resounded from every direction, pressing down on the figures prostrate on the floor.

“My servants.”

Everyone trembled at the overwhelming power in those two words. Some shook with fear of the absolute being before them; others with joy and rapture at seeing the one they served.

Together, they cried out.

“These foolish, lowly servants humbly pay their respects to the great Lord of Heaven!”

Lord of Heaven. Master of the heavens.

No other words could describe him.

An absolute being of unmatched dignity and greatness. The heavens above the clouds were his palace; every lowly creature on the earth below was his servant and subject.

No. They would make it so.

“How much time has passed?”

Every one of them understood the living god’s question. The figures prostrate before him were servants of the Lord of Heaven, loyal and devoted beyond words.

The young man bowing low against the floor was no different.

“Exactly one hundred and thirty-six days since the great Lord of Heaven last awoke!”

The fierce flames wavered at his answer.

“Yes. I remember. Western Heaven. That was the day the child left.”

“We are deeply ashamed!”

Led by the young man, they cried out again. This time, shame and self-reproach filled their voices.

When the Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Dark Heaven forces under his command had been annihilated at the Sichuan Tang Clan, the unexpected defeat had thrown them into confusion. They had been forced to wake their master from his deep sleep.

“Great Lord of Heaven, never again… will such a thing happen.”

The words came through the young man’s clenched teeth. The flames stirred once more.

“No. The mistake was mine, for trusting you despite your shortcomings.”

“…!”

“Blood Lord. You have your own shortcomings, do you not?”

At the most painful reprimand of all, the pupils of the young man—Blood Lord—trembled.

Blood Lord knew better than anyone what the master he worshiped meant.

Henan.

The day the orthodox Murim had named the Shaolin Bloodshed was one of the most painful memories of his life. He had accomplished far less than planned, and suffered the humiliation of leaving an arm behind.

If he hadn’t at least brought back Shaolin’s sacred treasure, the Green Jade Buddha Staff… He didn’t want to think about it.

The Sword Saint. And Jin Taekyung.

Thinking of those two bastards made him want to kill. Even tearing them apart alive wouldn’t satisfy him.

But a loyal servant must not show such thoughts before his master. Blood Lord barely suppressed his murderous intent and spoke.

“P-Please forgive me.”

Whoooong.

A chilly wind swept through the darkness in place of an answer. Blood Lord and the others huddled lower.

Then a quiet voice reached their ears.

“What is lacking can be filled.”

The air grew heavy. The wind stopped, and every living thing held its breath.

In the stillness, the Lord of Heaven continued.

“I shall fill what you lack.”

It was a command, backed by a force none of them could resist.

Fwooooooosh.

Darkness and shadow rippled.

An immense surge of qi flowed from somewhere unseen and settled into Blood Lord’s body. His eyes widened with rapture.

“L-Lord of Heaven!”

Blood Lord and the others understood once more: the master they served was a living god, an absolute being who encompassed heaven and earth.

They understood, too, what the power he had bestowed on them meant.

“Tell Southern Heaven and North Heaven.”

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The earth trembled. The world shook.

Beyond the overwhelming energy that distorted everything, his voice rang out like thunder.

“Now… we begin the Great War.”

Heaven above, earth below. All demons bow in submission.

As his loyal servants cried out in rapture and madness, the unseen shadow waved a hand.

The crimson-black flames that had colored the pitch-black space disappeared, and darkness descended once more.

Chapter 615

The road to Yunnan Province—the region officially known by that name, though people in the Central Plains commonly called it Nanman—was long and arduous.

Prrrff. Prrf.

The horse's breathing was ragged.

We had ridden without a break for a full four shichen[2754] since leaving Mount Daebyeol. Now, having entered Hubei on the fine horses Ju Hwaran had procured, we eased the reins for a moment in an unfamiliar ravine.

"If we keep traveling like this, it'll take quite a while. You've been to Sichuan before, Pavilion Master, so you know that, don't you?"

"Me?"

Of course I knew. Just thinking about it made my calves cramp even now.

I nodded without thinking as Ju Hwaran looked at me with her clear, sparkling eyes.

"Of course. It was really fucki—"

"Pardon?"

"It was a little… difficult. A little."

I'd barely stopped myself from saying that something had almost fallen off back then.

I, Jin Taekyung, was merciless toward men, but a warm and considerate gentleman toward women.

Of course, despite having lived this long, I had never once been in a relationship.

"Even using a movement technique, it took me nearly half a month."

"Sichuan alone is well over three thousand li[2755] away. And if you traveled without any shortcuts, that's remarkable."

The praise felt good, but she probably hadn't brought this up just to compliment me.

I gave her a questioning look. Ju Hwaran smiled and pulled an old leather scroll from inside her robes.

What's that?

Just as I began to wonder, Song Ilseom, who was sitting in the saddle and inspecting the edge of his willow-leaf saber, spoke with an unexpected look on his face.

"It's made of horsehide. Is that from the horse caravans?"

Ju Hwaran nodded.

"You recognize it. Yes—more precisely, it's a map they used."

[2754] A shichen is a traditional period of about two hours; four shichen is about eight hours.

[2755] A Chinese li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); three thousand li is about 1,500 km (932 mi).

"I heard you couldn't buy one of their maps for ten thousand gold pieces."

"As Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, I can tell you there's nothing in this world money can't buy. But my grandfather gained a friendship worth more than gold. He was given this map as a token of it."

Hmm. I see.

...Actually, I didn't understand a damn thing.

Except that Ju Hwaran's grandfather, Escort King Ju Gongsan, had received an amazing map from someone in these horse caravans.

After patiently listening to them, I spoke up.

"Um, Young Lady Ju. Sorry, but what exactly are the horse caravans?"

"They're descendants of the northern mounted tribes."

"For hundreds of years, they traveled the ancient trade routes, carrying goods between the Outer Lands and the Central Plains. There aren't nearly as many of them now."

"..."

Well, all right. Now I knew what the horse caravans were.

But I was pretty sure I had asked Ju Hwaran. Why were the answers coming from two dark-clad men?

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo, who had spoken almost at the same time, turned to look at each other.

"You're more knowledgeable than you look."

"Than I look? Have you forgotten where the Black Dragon Demon Gate is located? Horse caravans are still active in Gansu, where our sect is based."

"Operate? You mean they're being squeezed dry?"

Song Ilseom gave a short laugh.

"I've heard the rumors. The Black Dragon Demon Gate controls the trade routes and collects enormous tolls."

"I heard you were a wandering martial artist. Do you have some bad blood with our sect?"

"Not particularly. I just want to kill any demonic, heterodox practitioner I see."

"We agree on that point. I can't stand meeting people who draw their weapons before anything else. So, are you finished tending to your weapon?"

"Not yet. But it'll have blood on it soon enough, so I can finish later."

"Then let's move somewhere else for a while."

How the hell had the conversation gotten here?

I stared blankly at the two men as they amicably turned their horses around, then opened my mouth.

"Move where, you lunatics?"

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo answered at the same time.

"It's personal. Stay out of it."

"The horses need a rest anyway. Have some tea. We'll be back shortly."

"…"

One was an individualist. The other was Guan Yu.[2756]

The Nanman expedition had barely set out, and already it was showing signs of falling apart. As Fire Dragon Pavilion Master, I had to step in.

Whish!

Two sharp blasts cut through the air.

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo landed on the ground after avoiding the Finger Qi I had fired at them. Just as they reflexively began to draw their weapons, I warned them in a calm voice.

"You'll regret drawing those."

"…!"

"…!"

It wasn't just a warning. They felt the immense qi pressing in from every direction and froze.

Unmistakable astonishment appeared in their trembling eyes.

He's strong.

That was what their gazes said.

And it was an undeniable fact.

Sama Pyo, the Black Dragon Saber, was Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, the dominant power in Gansu, and the unorthodox faction's foremost young prodigy. Song Ilseom, the Soul-Chasing Guest, had become a legend by cutting down countless enemies on battlefields and in life-and-death duels. Both of them understood exactly what they were facing.

No—because they were anything but mediocre Peak masters, they understood it all the better.

A person standing at a higher place could see farther and grasp the whole picture.

I was already two moves above them before, but the pressure they're feeling now must be much greater.

As always, I had woken up stronger than I'd been when I fell asleep.

While developing a martial art that could be widely taught to modern Hunters, I'd gained a small insight. I hadn't created anything extraordinary, so I couldn't call it a full step forward…but even a quarter of a step was a significant gain.

It was a shame my allies were the first to feel the results instead of Dark Heaven.

[2756] Guan Yu is a legendary warrior of the Three Kingdoms era, famed for defeating an opponent before his wine could cool.

[2757] A Chinese li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); three thousand li is about 1,500 km (932 mi).

"We have thousands of li[2757] left to go. If you still want to fight, do it now and keep going until one of you dies. Otherwise—"

"Pavilion Master."

I was fond of Ju Hwaran, but now wasn't the time to listen to her. I gave her a slight shake of my head at her tense expression and continued.

"Otherwise, team up and come at me. This is your only chance. You won't get another."

"…"

"…"

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo stared at each other, lips pressed tight. It didn't take them long to decide.

Shrrrk. Click.

With a cold scraping sound, the two blades that had been faintly exposed disappeared from view.

They climbed back into their saddles as though nothing had happened. Ju Hwaran watched them and let out a quiet sigh.

"Whew… I'd hoped this wouldn't happen."

So had I. But I'd thought long and hard about the possibility before accepting those two into the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Their feelings toward each other probably aren't very good. Especially from Song Ilseom's perspective.

It went back decades, to when the orthodox and demonic factions had divided the world between them and fought their decisive battle.

A bold young escort named Zhu had accepted a woman's commission and made the Ten-Thousand-Mile Escorts a legend. The child that woman bore grew up, had a son, and passed away.

That son was Song Ilseom—the last descendant of the Guangdong Chen Family, which had been wiped out by demonic, heterodox arts.

Unless he was Buddha or Jesus, it was only natural that he would harbor hatred toward the unorthodox faction.

I just didn't think it would come to a head this fast.

Shit, how many shichen[2758] had we even been on the road? Was the whole expedition already about to fall apart? I was starting to understand why college students hated group projects.

And that was true even if I excluded the two men who had become archenemies faster than anyone in Murim history.

"Captain, maybe it's because I got hit in the stomach earlier, but I keep needing to take a shit."

[2758] A shichen is a traditional period of about two hours; four shichen is about eight hours.

“My lord. Don’t fight. Taishan worries when my lord is in danger. And gets hungry.”

“…”

Look at this lineup. For fuck’s sake.

Watching Hyuk Mujin, whose stomach was more active than his body, and Taishan, the Tiger Giant Child, who seemed to have an inventory instead of a stomach, made my vision go dark.

But even here, I had one ray of light.

“Young Lady Ju.”

“Yes?”

“Thank you. I’m really glad you’re here.”

I meant it. Beautiful or not, she was the most normal person in the group.

It was true that her martial arts were slightly weaker than those of the other members, but she had extensive knowledge of Murim and was excellent at finding her way.

The fact that she had found a shortcut known only among the horse caravans proved it.

So why wasn’t she answering?

“Young Lady Ju?”

“…”

“Um, Young Lady Ju?”

I called again, but she said nothing. Still gripping the reins, she turned her head away and stammered.

“I-I think we should go this way.”

“What? No, you’ve done a great job. I meant—”

“I’ll ride ahead and look for the horse caravans’ markers. Hyah!”

“Uh. Wait—what?”

I didn’t get another word out. Ju Hwaran hurried away as though she and her horse were one, leaving me staring blankly after her. Then I felt eyes prickling the back of my head and turned.

…What’s with these guys now?

Song Ilseom. Sama Pyo. Hyuk Mujin. Even Taishan.

Exactly four pairs of eyes were fixed in place, staring holes through me.

Their mysterious gazes were impossible to interpret. I flinched instinctively and asked,

“What? Why are you all looking at me like that?”

“Hmm. It’s nothing.”

“I’ll go on ahead, Pavilion Master.”

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo slowly rode forward, both wearing complicated expressions. Hyuk Mujin and Taishan answered reluctantly.

“Uh, I was just looking. Because I need to take a dump.”

“If you need to take a dump, why look at me?”

“When I look at you, whatever was about to come out goes right back in.”

“Taishan. Just looking because hungry. Nothing else.”

“What the hell does being hungry have to do with me?”

“Nothing. Just… just… Hmm. Taishan gets it now. Taishan understands a little.”

What kind of bullshit was that?

I could understand Hyuk Mujin, but having that giant glutton look at me with such pity was deeply unsettling.

Before I could press him, Taishan smacked his half-dead horse on the rump and charged off.

“Taishan! Go! Horse go too!”

The horse, already looking half-dead, staggered into a run. Hyuk Mujin hurried after him.

“Hey, wait! Let’s go together!”

“No! Don’t follow! Taishan only runs forward!”

“I have jerky.”

“Taishan! Found friend! Together forever!”

Lunatics…

But why did I feel like I was the one being ignored by those lunatics?

I grabbed my reins, my face twisting as though I’d bitten into something foul.

“Hey. Let’s go too.”

Prrrff.

“…”

Now even the damn horse was giving me a look.

I smacked its head as it snorted, then squeezed its sides hard. With a small whinny, it raced through the ravine.

Chapter 616

Becoming a successful merchant in Murim meant surviving fierce competition.

The map the horse caravans had reportedly made while traveling between the Outer Lands and the Central Plains was proof enough of how they had amassed such wealth.

“This is the place. The marker’s faint, but it’s definitely one of the horse caravans’.”

“Huh. Who would’ve thought there was a road through here?”

Secret shortcuts hidden throughout the Central Plains, swift and accurate despite their concealment.

Some had vanished over the years, and those that remained could be treacherous precisely because they were hidden. But that wasn’t much of a problem for us.

“Captain, isn’t this slope too steep?”

“It is. The road’s narrow, too. But we have to go.”

“Then I’m afraid we’ll have to leave the horses behind.”

“Why would we do that? We can carry them.”

“Pardon?”

Correction. It wasn’t much of a problem for *me*.

Everyone who heard me stared wide-eyed.

“What did you say?”

“They’re not big warhorses. They came from the grasslands, so they’re fairly light, aren’t they?”

“…Light or not, they’re horses. Can you really carry them?”

As it turned out, I could. More easily than I’d expected, in fact.

My strength had long since surpassed human limits. I slung two horses over my shoulders and strode uphill, while Taishan—who wasn’t as strong as me but was a natural strongman with the build to match—could manage three.

“Pavilion Master. Taishan. Heavy. No choice. Eat one horse here. No, leave one here.”

“…Swallow your spit and try saying that again.”

His appetite was a bigger problem than the weight.

And as the shortcuts cut down our travel time and distance, greater obstacles waited for us.

“According to the map, there should be a road ahead. But…”

“It’s gone. Or rather, blocked.”

“Escort Song is right. I heard there was a landslide nearby a month or two ago. That must have blocked it.”

"Then we'll have to go around. The map says this road runs for at least ten li.[2759] If only a few dozen *jang*[2760] were buried, perhaps, but clearing a road like this is out of the question… Pavilion Master, what are you doing?"

"Getting ready to clear the road."

"What?"

"It's not like we have to tunnel through the mountain. Clear some dirt, move a few rocks and boulders, and we should be able to get through. You said the landslide was only a month or two ago, right?"

"Well, yes, but…"

"As they say, when the body is weak, the head has to work harder."

"…That sounds wrong. Isn't it usually the other way around?"

"Usually."

For days, we carried horses up mountains, dug through buried roads, and walked and ran until we crossed Hubei and reached Sichuan at a ridiculous pace.

We owed it all to Ju Hwaran. She knew the shortcuts once shared by only a handful of horse caravans, and she remembered everything her maternal grandfather—the Escort King—had left behind.

I can't believe we got here so quickly.

We'd made this kind of time without even taking the waterways.

Granted, I'd played no small part in making the impossible possible. But Hwaran had more than fulfilled the role she'd promised to take on before joining the Fire Dragon Pavilion. She'd exceeded my expectations.

Martial arts really aren't everything.

No matter how much of a Supreme Peak master I became, I couldn't do anything like this. I gave Ju Hwaran a heartfelt exclamation of admiration.

"You're incredible. There's no one like you, Young Lady Ju."

"I-I'll go feed the horses some hay."

"What? Why? They aren't Taishan. How long has it even been since they ate hay… Young Lady Ju? Young Lady Ju?"

What the hell was going on?

At this point, I couldn't tell whether she couldn't hear me or had decided not to listen.

As I watched Ju Hwaran hurry away using a movement technique, I turned my head at the gaze I felt from beside me.

Swish!

The movement was quick as lightning, but not quick enough to escape my notice. I eyed the culprit.

[2759] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is 500 m (about 0.311 mi). Ten *li* are about 5 km (3.1 mi).

[2760] One *jang* is about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

"Hey."

He flinched.

"I saw you. Don't pretend you weren't looking."

Song Ilseom, seated by the water, glanced around awkwardly.

"Hmm. Are you speaking to me?"

"You're the only one here. And you know you look awkward as hell, right?"

"…I have no idea what you mean."

"If you were watching, you were watching. Why hide it? And do you sharpen that willow-leaf saber every chance you get? It'll be a needle by the time we reach Nanman."

Splash.

Song Ilseom poured water over the blade, polished so carefully it gleamed like a mirror. His face hardened.

"Watch what you say. This weapon means something to me."

He wasn't particularly expressive to begin with, but he'd gone so serious that there had to be a story behind it.

Then again, he's been through a lot.

There was no excuse for reopening someone else's wounds. Thinking I'd made a careless mistake, I spoke cautiously.

"Is it a treasured blade passed down through your family?"

"Hardly. I was told they couldn't bring out so much as a single martial arts manual. My grandmother never learned martial arts in her life. The fact that she survived that war was a miracle."

"Right. It did look pretty worn for a treasured blade. Something your father left you, then?"

"No."

A wistful smile touched Song Ilseom's lips, as if he were remembering better days. He ran a hand along the blade.

"I received this willow-leaf saber when I was young, while serving as a sword boy for a Third Rate wandering martial artist. I cut a person with it for the first time in my life. I was probably twelve."

"…Oh. Right."

Wounds, my ass.

My budding guilt melted away like spring snow.

He'd been a martial artist from the start. Watching Song Ilseom fondly recall his first killing, I could only think he was… out of his mind.

Yeah. He's not right in the head either.

Murim had all kinds of people, but lunatics made up a good share of them. Maybe you had to be one to survive here.

You could die over a meal. You could die in a fight. You could survive the fight, only to die when your wounds got worse. You could endure enough hardship to become a master, then die from qi deviation during training.

What was that novel called? I read one where a martial artist retired peacefully with golden-basin handwashing.[2761]

It took coming to Murim to realize that a novel was just a novel.

I'd once asked Jeok Cheongang about golden-basin handwashing.[2762] His answer had gone like this:

"Golden-basin handwashing?[2763] Easy."

"Oh. It is?"

"Of course. First, buy a basin made of gold and invite plenty of close acquaintances."

"It already reeks of social butterflies and capitalism, but all right. What next?"

"Wash your hands without a care. Of course, the moment you take your hand off your weapon, an assassin hidden among your acquaintances will throw a hidden weapon at you."

"Ah…"

"And one more thing. The person you thought was an acquaintance might be an assassin, too. What do you think? Isn't it easy?"

As my dear Fire-Rice Grandpa had so wisely put it, that was fucking Murim for you.

Golden-basin handwashing,[2764] my ass. Most martial artists should be grateful just to wake up in the morning and wash their faces with ice water.

After all, the next day they might have to bathe and purify themselves in the waters of the Sanzu River[2765] instead of ice water.

I supposed that counted as retirement, too. The only difference was whether you were still breathing.

What is this, Murim Escape Number One?[2766]

The old show had been canceled, but a Murim edition would be a smash hit. Assuming television caught on here, it might pull a 107 percent viewership rating, like turnout in a Russian presidential election.

They could hire a master of demonic, heterodox arts as their experiment expert. He'd smile warmly and run the demonstration himself.

"All right, fellow martial artists. What happens if you dodge this form like so?"

[2761] A ceremonial retirement from martial pursuits, marked by washing one's hands in a golden basin.

[2762] A ceremonial retirement from martial pursuits, marked by washing one's hands in a golden basin.

[2763] A ceremonial retirement from martial pursuits, marked by washing one's hands in a golden basin.

[2764] A ceremonial retirement from martial pursuits, marked by washing one's hands in a golden basin.

[2765] In Buddhist tradition, the Sanzu River marks the boundary between life and death.

[2766] A reference to *Emergency Escape Number One*, a Korean television program about avoiding everyday dangers.

Stab.

“See? Dead. Heh heh.”

They’d run out of experimenters in no time…

It was only my imagination, but Murim was the kind of place where it could become reality as soon as someone brought in a TV.

And in this insane world, I had to travel with lunatics and fight more lunatics.

“…Whew.”

I was staring silently at the river, feeling sorry for myself, when Song Ilseom spoke.

“I was watching.”

“Hm? Watching what?”

“What happened earlier. I never answered you.”

So that was what he meant. I shrugged.

“I knew you were watching. Why were you staring?”

“I heard something, so I looked.”

“Try being honest.”

“Your words and actions looked so stupid that I couldn’t help staring.”

“…Wow. That’s a little too honest.”

“But it’s true. Isn’t that why Young Lady Ju keeps leaving whenever you say things like that?”

For some reason, I felt wronged.

“What did I do? I was impressed, so I gave her an honest compliment.”

“Even a passing dog wouldn’t believe that.”

“It’s true.”

“Enough. It isn’t funny.”

“I haven’t found any of this funny.”

“Fine. Let’s say it’s true.”

Song Ilseom let out a quiet laugh, as though I’d made a joke. Then he saw my expression, and his own turned uncertain.

“Is it true?”

“I keep telling you it is.”

“You’re saying that, in all honesty, you have no idea what your words and actions mean? No idea why Young Lady Ju leaves every time?”

“I swear to heaven. I’ll stake my balls on it.”

“Huh. You’re staking your own balls instead of Hyuk Mujin’s… Then it must be true.”

The verification process seemed odd, but he believed me now, so I let it pass.

Song Ilseom stared at me as if he’d seen a unicorn.

“How can anyone be this clueless?”

"What?"

"Wasn't your old sobriquet the Night King? You'd think you would at least know the basics."

"…"

How long would I have to clean up the shit that promiscuous predecessor had left behind? If they'd called him the Porn King, I could have admitted there was some truth to it. But the Night King?

"…It's a long story."

Song Ilseom nodded at my weary reply.

"Of course. You must have spent many long nights."

"You son of a bitch. Draw your sword. You're fucking dead today."

"Unfortunately, we'll have to put that off until later. Thanks to you, I have to find an employer who still hasn't appeared even after fifteen minutes."

"You seem to have forgotten I'm the Fire Dragon Pavilion Master. Your direct superior."

"But my employer is the one who pays me silver nyang.[2767] Protecting her is my job."

Song Ilseom sheathed his freshly polished willow-leaf saber and rose from the water's edge.

Crunch. Crunch.

He turned away without another word, his feet pressing into sand and gravel. Then he stopped.

"If you don't know why Young Lady Ju acts that way, think about it carefully with that nonexistent sense of tact you have. You have to find the answer yourself."

"What?"

"She may look strong, but she's suffered a great deal. I hope she doesn't get hurt—or die for nothing."

That was all.

I watched him walk on as though nothing had happened, and a thought came to me.

Is silver nyang[2768] really why he's stayed by Ju Hwaran's side all this time?

Before I could find an answer, a sound rang across the surging waters of the Yangtze in Sichuan.

Boom. Ba-boom. Boom!

Drums beat hard. Ship prows cut swiftly and forcefully through the current.

A dozen or so swift ships emerged from the fog, flags of the Water Dragon Stronghold fluttering above them.

[2767] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of currency; a silver nyang is denominated in silver.

[2768] A *nyang* is a traditional unit of currency; a silver nyang is denominated in silver.

“Our taxi’s here,” I muttered.

Chapter 617

Splash!

A dozen or so swift ships were approaching the riverbank. Anyone who wasn't blind could see them.

For a martial artist who had reached a realm stage, spotting them was even easier.

"Water Dragon Stronghold…"

Sama Pyo rushed over using his movement technique. He narrowed his eyes at the ships' flags, then turned to me.

"You told me to wait. Was this why?"

"Yep."

"Sichuan is a land filled with treacherous terrain, so if we travel down the Yangtze, we can certainly move faster than we are now. Still, I'm somewhat concerned that our counterparts are the Yangtze River Channel League."

He had reason to distrust them. The Yangtze River Channel League was, at its core, a band of water bandits who made their living by plunder. And the prevailing opinion was that its leader, the Seafaring King Pa Ryun, was a devious man, regardless of his martial prowess.

He didn't attend the formation of the Murim Alliance, either, for some reason.

I didn't know whether illness or distance had kept him away. He had sent an envoy to announce his intention to join, then made it official. The Green Forest Alliance had done the same.

Both groups were closer to the unorthodox faction than the orthodox one. More accurately, they were plunderers who had carved out powerful domains of their own.

"I hear Pa Ryun is impossible to read," Sama Pyo said. "Rumors about him have been circulating quietly even in Henan."

"That he'll side with Dark Heaven when the time comes? That kind of rumor?"

"So you've heard."

"Are my ears just decoration? And since you brought up what people say…"

I looked at him and lowered my voice.

"By that standard, the Yangtze River Channel League and the Black Dragon Demon Gate are two of a kind."

"…"

"Am I wrong?"

After a brief silence, Sama Pyo answered with a sour look.

"Now that I think about it, you may be right."

"Not *may be*. I am, you bastard. Look closely and the Black Dragon Demon Gate might be worse. At least those guys rob orthodox and unorthodox factions alike. There's no denying which side you're on."

"…I understand. You can stop. Listening to this is making my head spin."

Taishan, who had been prowling around Sama Pyo like an enormous dog, joined in.

"Lord. Taishan hungry too. Head spinning."

"…"

Watching you two is making my head spin.

I rubbed my throbbing temple and opened my mouth.

"And one more thing. You can trust those water bandits, so stop worrying."

"Trustworthy water bandits? You might as well tell me there's a martial artist who's never learned martial arts."

"It's a long story, but we've got a pretty strong bond."

I didn't know what kind of man the Seafaring King Pa Ryun was. Even if everything people said about him was true, though, it wouldn't change my opinion of Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song.

The Mu Song I knew kept his word and held to his principles. A disciple didn't necessarily take after his master.

The fact that they came as soon as I sent word from Sichuan says enough.

While I was thinking that, the swift ships reached the bank and a dozen or so men poured ashore.

Splash!

They moved with the rough energy of bandits who knew the Yangtze inside and out, sending river water spraying in every direction. Bronze-colored muscles showed through their loose robes as they raced over and clasped their hands in salute.

"Great Hero Jin!"

"We came as fast as we could when we got your message."

These were Mu Song's trusted men, all squad leaders or higher in the Water Dragon Stronghold. I'd seen them several times a day on my last visit to Sichuan, but the face I knew best was missing.

"All familiar faces. But I don't see Senior Mu Song."

The Deputy Stronghold Lord answered at once.

"I'm sorry to say he left for headquarters two days ago."

"Headquarters… The Yangtze River Channel League's?"

"Yes, sir. It was on the League Leader's orders, so he couldn't delay even a moment."

"I see."

Within the Yangtze River Channel League, the Seafaring King's orders were absolute. His direct Disciple, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song, had no choice but to answer a summons.

I looked over the bandits, disappointed that I'd missed him but grateful they had come.

"You still got here quickly, even with Senior Mu Song away."

The Deputy Stronghold Lord waved his hands in alarm.

"Oh, please don't say that. The Stronghold Lord must have seen this coming. Before he left, he gave us strict instructions about you."

"About me?"

"Yes, sir. He said a person ought to repay a favor. And considering what happened with the late Yangtze One Saber, Great Hero Hwang, he told us to do everything we could if the Jin Family of Taiyuan or Great Hero Jin ever needed help."

"Oh. Senior Mu Song understands loyalty. A true hero."

See that, you bastard?

I smiled at Sama Pyo. Just then, a burly bandit beside the deputy leaned in and whispered, looking puzzled.

"Deputy Stronghold Lord."

"Hm?"

"Didn't the Stronghold Lord also say Great Hero Jin would raise hell if we didn't help? That we should give him whatever he wanted instead of letting him wreck perfectly good swift ships?"

"Ah. Uh. Jang Pil, you little—!"

"…"

"…"

Silence fell.

Never mind the water bandits. The gazes of the proud members of our Fire Dragon Pavilion were painfully sharp.

In the hush, Ju Hwaran murmured so quietly I could barely hear her.

"What on earth have you been doing to make even water bandits…"

That went straight through me. I looked out over the endless Yangtze, my chest tightening.

I wanted to make an excuse, but I *had* thrown tantrums and treated their ships like taxis. I couldn't say a thing.

"In some ways, you're worse than the unorthodox faction," Sama Pyo muttered.

I did my best to ignore his final blow and turned mournful eyes on the deputy.

"Let's just get going."

"Y-yes, sir."

"And come see me later. Bring Jang Pil, too."

"…"

The Deputy Stronghold Lord stared at me in terror for a moment before shouting in a choked voice,

"Raise the anchor! Raise the anchor!"

I must have imagined the tears in his voice.

Whoosh!

The ship's bow cut swiftly and powerfully through the water.

Spring had arrived, and the wind was at our backs. Years of plunder had made the bandits peerless rowers.

Of course, even though these were fairly decent water bandits who had been reformed by Mu Song, their innate instincts remained.

"Five ships to the southeast!"

"Deputy Stronghold Lord, they're sizable merchant ships!"

"Merchant ships? Let's rob them!"

Rob them? Now? You lunatics.

Everyone watched in disbelief, myself included. The Deputy Stronghold Lord's face twisted.

"You idiots! We have honored guests aboard! What do you think you're doing? Do you people have no basic manners?"

"S-sorry."

For a water bandit, he sounded exactly like Judge Bao.[2769]

After sternly rebuking his subordinates, the Deputy Stronghold Lord approached us and bowed politely.

"I apologize for letting you see us behave that way."

"Heh heh. Think nothing of it."

I gave him an amiable smile.

"I understand. Robbing ships is your line of work. I can see how it happened."

"Thank you for understanding. We'll rob them quickly and get back on our way."

"Huh?"

"Half a shichen[2770] at most. We'll take a little off them and let them go…"

"Get down."

There had been a slight incident, but after I made the Deputy Stronghold Lord drop and hold the push-up position a few times, even that impulse disappeared.

[2769] Judge Bao, or Bao Qingtian, is a legendary incorruptible magistrate celebrated in Chinese folklore and popular fiction.

[2770] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

All the while, the swift ship kept moving with the wind at its back.

One day passed. Then two. Then three…

Aboard the ship, the Fire Dragon Pavilion members each settled into their own preparations.

Swish! Whoosh!

After that first day, Sama Pyo and Song Ilseom trained in their respective martial arts without clashing again.

“Taishan likes sashimi.[2771] But no fish caught. Give Taishan one.”

“You’ve got some nerve. I worked hard to catch these few fish, and you want me to hand one over? Captain, he won’t leave me alone. Can you get him off my back?”

“Give me all the fish you’ve caught so far. Slice them into sashimi first, obviously.”

“Taishan impressed. Is Pavilion Master a genius?”

“…”

Hyuk Mujin and Taishan spent most of their time fishing at the bow.

They often caught nothing. When Mujin did catch fish, someone else usually took them. He hardly complained, but I knew it wasn’t because he’d given up.

He wasn’t fishing to catch fish in the first place.

That’s why he doesn’t say anything.

Hyuk Mujin fished to clear his mind, even if only for a while.

Even when the bobber trembled right in front of him, he didn’t bother yanking on the fishing rod. Every night, he locked himself in the cabin to practice martial arts or devote himself to circulating his qi.

Day by day, hour by hour, we drew closer to Yunnan. Everyone was preparing in their own way for a fight that might come.

I was no different.

Open the Quest window.

Ding.

[2771] Sashimi is a Japanese dish of thinly sliced raw fish or seafood.

SYSTEM

Quest
Journey to Nanman
Murim Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak has assigned the Fire Dragon Pavilion its first mission.
You must now head to Nanman and actively respond to any situation that may arise.
There is no way to know what lies ahead for you and the Fire Dragon Pavilion.
Always remain vigilant and act with a flexible mindset.
Grade: Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung and Fire Dragon Pavilion members
Mission: Enter Nanman (Incomplete)
Reward: Chain Quest
???
Failure: Obtain Title: Can't Go to Nanman
Fame and trust greatly reduced

In Murim time, I'd received that Quest about half a month ago. Counting my time in the modern world, it had been over a month.

I was studying the Quest Window again for anything I might have missed when a faint floral scent drifted in on the breeze.

"Why are you staring so hard at empty space?"

It was Ju Hwaran.

I closed the holographic window and gazed solemnly at the star-filled sky.

"I was reading the heavenly patterns."

"Oh. Really?"

"Yes, really."

"That's impressive."

She gave a quiet laugh.

"So what did the heavens tell you?"

"They said the weather would be nice today."

"Really?"

"Yes. Young Lady Ju, see the Big Dipper over there?"

Ju Hwaran looked up at the sky along my pointing finger and blinked.

"Uh. Um."

"What?"

"Pavilion Master, I'm sorry, but that isn't the Big Dipper."

"...That can't be right. Did it change shape while I wasn't looking?"

"What?"

What the hell kind of answer was that?

I realized how ridiculous it sounded as soon as I said it. I scratched my chin, flustered, and Ju Hwaran burst out laughing.

"That's an interesting way to read the heavenly patterns."

"Honestly, I don't know how to read them. I just deal with whatever comes up as best I can."

"I know. But now I want to hear more. There's something I've been wondering about. May I ask?"

I smacked my lips.

"I already told you I can't read the heavenly patterns."

"And I already told you I know. I don't want to ask the heavens. I want to ask you."

"In that case, go ahead. I'll answer if I can."

Tap.

Ju Hwaran lightly jumped onto the bow and looked out at the pitch-black river before opening her mouth.

"What do you think will happen from here on? To us?"

Nanman was close now. She had to be anxious.

I thought for a moment about how to reassure her.

"I don't know. There's a strong possibility that Dark Heaven is plotting something, but it's also possible that nothing will happen."

Nanman was remote enough to be counted among the Outer Lands. It was also a vast territory home to the Nanman Beast Palace, the dominant power in Nanman, as well as numerous ethnic groups, including the Miao people.

If my forebodings were right and Dark Heaven was plotting something there, countless dangers awaited the Fire Dragon Pavilion and me.

But…

"Nothing will happen to us. Whatever we face, we'll make it home safely. I can promise you that."

Ju Hwaran didn't answer. Instead, she watched me with an unreadable look for a moment—no, for a long time.

"Young Lady Ju?"

"…I see."

At last she spoke. A faint smile touched her lips, and she shook her head gently. Her glossy hair, which even the human-skin mask couldn't hide, rippled like the river.

"I'll trust you, Pavilion Master."

"…?"

Something felt off. I was wondering whether I’d said the wrong thing when the Deputy Stronghold Lord appeared carrying a torch, his face flushed.

“Great Hero Jin. We’ve arrived.”

“…!”

Chapter 618

The air had grown hot and muggy. In the distance, high mountains and deep valleys came into view.

The Deputy Stronghold Lord of the Water Dragon Stronghold pointed toward the rapidly approaching shore.

“This is as far as we can take you, Great Hero Jin. Once you disembark, head straight on for ten li[2772] and you’ll be in Yunnan. It won’t take long.”

The Yangtze’s tributaries stretched across a vast part of the continent, but they didn’t reach the interior of Yunnan Province.

No, that wasn’t strictly true. The waterways didn’t simply end there.

The problem was that continuing by water to the plateau in northern Yunnan would take us much longer to reach our destination.

Our highest priority is the Nanman Beast Palace, after all.

The Quest I had received required me to reach Nanman, but the Fire Dragon Pavilion’s mission required us to head for the Nanman Beast Palace.

I gave the Deputy Stronghold Lord a small bow.

“Thank you. You must be busy raiding merchant ships, yet you brought us all the way here.”

“Oh, please, don’t say that. You’re no ordinary person. If Great Hero Jin calls for us, we should drop everything and come running at any time. I’m almost sorry to part ways with you, heh heh heh.”

He looked far too happy for someone who was supposedly sorry.

Then again, I’d made him bang his head against the ground and hold a push-up position in front of his men whenever the mood struck me. He probably was happy to say goodbye.

I laughed along with him. “Ha ha. Really?”

“Of course. Heh heh.”

“Then it would be perfect if you stayed nearby, wouldn’t it?”

“Heh heh heh. What?”

“I was worried about how we’d get back after we finished here. But if you’re sorry to part ways, that solves it.”

“…!”

“So wait nearby.”

The smile vanished from the Deputy Stronghold Lord’s face. He stammered, “Ah, no. That might be a little difficult. We have things to do as well…”

“I know. You can send the rest of the ships back and leave just one or two here.”

[2772] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

“G-Great Hero Jin, please. Wouldn’t it be better if you sent word once you’d finished your business in Yunnan?”

“Hmm. But then I’d have to wait too long.”

“…”

There was no trace of happiness left on his face. As he hung his head, I gently rubbed his shoulder.

“I know it’s an unreasonable request, but let’s impose on you a little.”

“No, even so…”

“Come on. Let’s impose on you a little.”

“…”

“Ah, fuck. Answer me already. You’ve got to know how to conduct yourself if you want to survive in Murim.”

“Gasp.”

The Deputy Stronghold Lord’s face went dark. His answer was all but decided.

A short while later, I finally extracted a promise that they would remain anchored nearby until we returned. After I disembarked, the gazes directed at me were far from ordinary.

“I thought I was watching a Third Rate wandering martial artist.”

“I mean no offense by this, but does the Jin Family of Taiyuan have roots in the unorthodox faction?”

“That’s our Captain. You never disappoint.”

“Taishan thought Pavilion Master was a water bandit.”

“I think the Pavilion Master made the right decision. If something happens in Nanman, we can ask them for help. Don’t you agree?”

That last answer was the only correct one.

As expected, Ju Hwaran is the only person who understands me.

I turned to her, moved. “Exactly. You said what I was thinking, down to the last word.”

“Oh! Is that really what you were thinking?”

“Huh?”

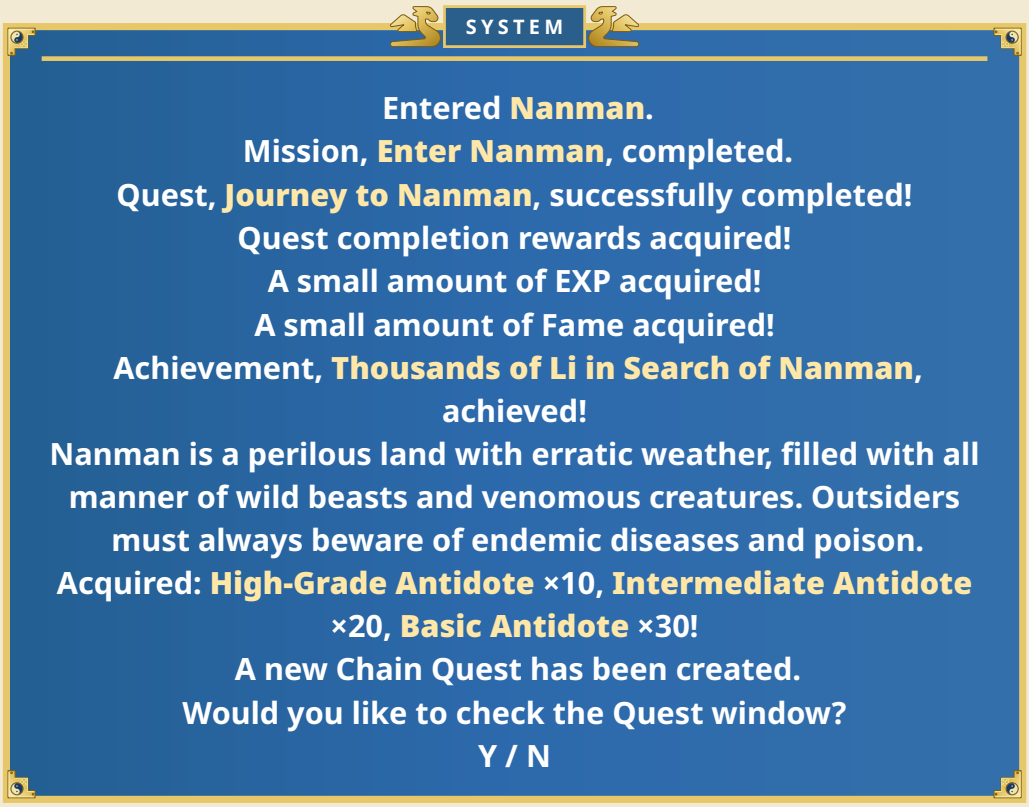
“I only took your side because everyone else was criticizing you. I thought someone should support the Pavilion Master…”

“…”

Is my image really okay as it is?

I was still pondering that as we walked along a crude road nothing like those in the Central Plains. Then a familiar sound rang in my ears.

Ding.



System notifications sounded one after another as holographic windows filled the air.

The Deputy Stronghold Lord had been telling the truth. We hadn't seen a single person nearby, but after walking for a short while, we had apparently stepped into Nanman territory.

Pretending nothing had happened, I answered in my head.

Confirm.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest

Seeds Planted in Nanman

You have arrived in Nanman after traveling thousands of li[2773], but Nanman is sparsely populated and outsiders are not welcome.

With your limited knowledge and information, you cannot afford to act rashly. Make contact with the Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent the Murim Alliance planted in Nanman long ago and obtain detailed information.

Grade: Peak

Restriction: Jin Taekyung and Fire Dragon Pavilion members

Mission: Make contact with the Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent (Incomplete)

Reward: Chain Quest

???

Failure: Stats decreased

Hmm.

Make contact with a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent.

I read the new Chain Quest several times, then recalled a conversation I'd had with Song Ho, the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, before leaving Henan.

"After the Great Faction War ended and the first Alliance Leader, the Martial God, disappeared, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion was disbanded. But even now, decades later, enough people remain to keep its intelligence network alive."

"You mean…"

"Didn't I tell you? The Hidden Shadow Pavilion has eyes and ears everywhere."

After the Great War that had shaken the world ended, people had gradually settled into peace. But not everyone had.

The Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho and the Hidden Shadow Pavilion certainly hadn't.

"They've stayed at their posts all these years with nothing but a sense of duty to a greater cause and the courage to see it through. Find our man as soon as you reach Nanman. He'll be able to give you information and plenty of help besides."

"How am I supposed to find him? You're not just going to give me his name and address, are you?"

"There's a secret code known only to Hidden Shadow Pavilion agents. I'll tell you where to go to verify it. You should be able to meet him there."

[2773] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

It struck me again how remarkable that was. Nearly fifty years had passed since the Great Faction War, yet the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's intelligence network was still alive.

Especially in a backwater like Nanman. They must have wanted to leave.

Thanks to their sacrifice, though, the Fire Dragon Pavilion's mission could become much easier.

After sorting out my thoughts, I spoke to the Fire Dragon Pavilion members as they moved forward while keeping watch over their surroundings.

"We're going to Yeongin."

"Yeongin?"

Hyuk Mujin tilted his head. "Never heard of it. Where is it?"

"It's a county seat about two hundred li[2774] from here. Much less developed than any county seat in the Central Plains, of course."

Ju Hwaran had answered for me. She went on, "Several different ethnic groups live there together. That doesn't mean they never clash, though."

Something about how readily she answered caught my attention. "Have you been there before?"

Ju Hwaran smiled and nodded.

"Didn't I tell you? Three years ago, I finally pestered my father into letting me join an escort journey to Nanman."

"Oh. So that was Yeongin."

"Yes. I wasn't there long, but I still remember it vividly. Captain Song came along too."

Everyone turned to Song Ilseom. He raised an eyebrow.

"I never want to come to Nanman again. It was a horrible place. But Yeongin was relatively tolerable. The ethnic groups there were comparatively mild-tempered."

From Song Ilseom, that was high praise.

Then again, that must have been why he had been able to escort a shipment across this rough and dangerous land of Nanman.

"But why are we going to Yeongin?" Ju Hwaran asked.

Now everyone looked at me. They'd probably wanted to ask from the start and had held back.

There was no reason to hide it. "I'm planning to meet a Murim Alliance informant there."

"Then we certainly need to go. News from Nanman rarely reaches the outside world."

Nanman was about as remote as a place could get.

[2774] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

Dozens of ethnic groups lived deep in its jungles. They were deeply wary of the Han Chinese from the Central Plains, and they had fought countless wars among themselves to defend their territories.

That was why even major Escort Bureaus and merchant companies were reluctant to make the journey. A successful trip could bring back spices, medicinal herbs, and rare gems—but the dangers lurking in the jungle could cost them their lives.

Even without an ethnic group suffering from anger-management issues, countless poisonous creatures, wild beasts, and highly lethal endemic diseases were serious obstacles.

“But Yeongin should be fine,” Ju Hwaran said with a bright smile. “Our Yongbong Escort Bureau has had ties with the people there since the time of its former leaders, and the ethnic groups living there are relatively friendly toward the Han Chinese.”

“Oh. Is that so?”

“Yes. You’ll see when you meet them. They’re good people.”

Hk, ptui.

A glob of sticky phlegm landed by our feet.

Living up to the name Bai, or “White,” a tribesman dressed in white glared menacingly at us before disappearing from sight.

I watched him go, then turned cautiously to Ju Hwaran.

“Um, I’m asking just in case, but does someone like that count as one of the nicer ones among the ethnic groups?”

“…”

“Young Lady Ju?”

After a pause, she said, “Hmm. That man seems a bit rough. Most people aren’t like that.”

“Right?”

“Yes, yes. Of course. I know because I’ve been here myself.”

The moment Ju Hwaran finished speaking, a middle-aged ethnic woman dressed in clothes as colorful as a peacock covered a child’s eyes and muttered,

“My word. Those Han bastards had the nerve to come all the way here. Let’s go inside before the sight of them ruins your eyes.”

“Mom. Mom. I can’t see.”

“It’s okay, sweetheart. Let’s hurry away from those vicious men. Honey! Come out quickly! Han bastards have entered the village!”

“What? Wait there. I’ll get my plow and smash those Han sons of bitches’ heads in!”

"…"

"…"

For an instant, Ju Hwaran's pupils shook violently.

Clinging to one last shred of hope, I asked, "They're just a little rougher than average too, right?"

"…Probably. I think."

But Ju Hwaran's hopes were brutally ignored.

Before long, the ethnic tribesmen filling the roadside began openly displaying their hostility toward us.

"So they really are Han Chinese."

"They've got some nerve. Send word to the chief at once."

"I already sent someone."

"Get the women and children indoors. Gather the men and keep an eye on those Han bastards."

I felt like a criminal.

No. To them, we were already criminals who deserved to be torn apart and killed.

The others could feel it too, even though they couldn't rely on the System to translate for them as I could, or speak the local language as Ju Hwaran did.

"Captain."

"What?"

"I think we're fucked."

Hyuk Mujin swallowed hard and went on in a whisper. "I don't know what they're saying, but the atmosphere is extremely hostile. Wouldn't it be better to get out of here?"

Hmm.

A leader's job included calming his subordinates. I answered sternly.

"It's not like that."

"It isn't?"

"No. They're staring because they're curious about Han Chinese."

"Then why do they have axes?"

"They probably came over after chopping firewood."

"And the swords?"

"They probably came over after slaughtering something."

"…"

Don't look at me like that. I feel guilty enough.

I did my best to ignore Hyuk Mujin's distrustful gaze and crossed through the ethnic tribesmen radiating a menacing aura. I stopped in front of a wooden building.

Poison Flower Pavilion

The sign was so old it looked ready to crumble. This was the meeting place the Thousand-Faced Fox had told me about.

Chapter 619

Poison Flower Pavilion…

A fitting name for a place in Nanman, where venomous beasts were everywhere. The catch was that it looked less like an inn or pleasure house than a mansion ready to collapse.

If the Thousand-Faced Fox's directions were right, this should be the place.

I eyed the decrepit wooden building with suspicion. Around us, the mood grew more hostile by the second.

"You fucking Han bastards!"

"Go back to your own land!"

Whoosh! Crack!

Sama Pyo dodged a rock flying at the back of his head and muttered with a sigh, "Pavilion Master, we'd better go inside. Unless you intend to fight them right now."

"That's out of the question."

For once, he was absolutely right. We couldn't make enemies of every local in Nanman the moment we arrived.

I glanced at the crowd radiating a menacing aura, then opened the door to the Poison Flower Pavilion.

Creeeak.

The old wooden door gave a feeble scrape.

Dim light and a gloomy air filled the inn. A few crude tables stood far apart, like weeds growing here and there. The patrons seated at them turned toward us.

"Never seen those faces before… Han Chinese?"

Hk, ptui.

Were they Hydras?

People around here used phlegm like a passive Skill.

The ethnic patrons spat onto the dusty floor and rose from their seats, their faces flushed red.

"Han bastards dare come here? Do they want to die?"

"They've ruined the taste of my liquor. Let's go. Nothing good will come of staying here with them."

Bang!

Once the door slammed shut behind them, Ju Hwaran spoke with a troubled expression. "Something must have gone badly wrong. It wasn't like this the last time I came."

Song Ilseom nodded. "I agree. The ethnic groups of Nanman are wary of outsiders, but Yeongin was different. It's the place closest to the Central Plains."

“Exactly. Merchant groups and Escort Bureaus from the Central Plains used to pass through here. It wasn’t common, but it happened. So why…”

As Hwaran trailed off, an elderly voice cut in.

“Why? Because of an Escort Bureau. Han bastards just like you.”

We weren’t the only ones left in the Poison Flower Pavilion.

An old man who had been sleeping off his liquor until a moment ago thumped his bent back and went on. “Bad luck all around. For you lot, crawling into Nanman without knowing what’s happened. And for a certain old man whose business is about to dry up because of those fearless Han bastards.”

I realized who he was. “Are you the owner?”

The old man looked at me in surprise when I spoke the local language fluently.

“You can speak our language. Are you perhaps one of the Miao people?”

“No.”

“Then you don’t look like the Bai or Man people either. Judging by your face, you’re definitely Han Chinese… but you speak remarkably well. I’d believe you were born and raised here.”

As expected of the *Integrated Language Pack*. It certainly did its job.

Even Ju Hwaran looked surprised by my pronunciation. “When did you learn their language?”

“Well…”

I couldn’t exactly explain it, so I let the answer trail off before saying casually, “I picked it up somewhere along the way. Just a little trick.”

Beside me, Hyuk Mujin muttered under his breath, “I thought drinking, women, and gambling were the only tricks our Captain knew…”

“You little shit.”

Bam!

“Urgh!”

Mujin collapsed clutching his solar plexus. The old man clicked his tongue.

“That one sure knows how to get himself hit.”

“He’s always like that, so don’t mind him… Wait. You speak Chinese?”

“To a degree. I served as an interpreter for Han Chinese several times when I was young.”

As though it were nothing, the old man pointed a bony finger at Song Ilseom.

“That dark-looking fellow seems familiar. Were you here about three years ago?”

Ju Hwaran should have stood out most, but perhaps her human-skin mask was why he recognized Song Ilseom first.

Song Ilseom nodded silently. The old man slapped his knee.

“I knew it. Your name was something like Dragon King…”

“Yongbong Escort Bureau. Not Dragon King.”

"Right, Yongbong Escort Bureau. Unlike the other merchant groups and Escort Bureaus from the Central Plains, you Han Chinese came by two or three times a year. I remember you clearly."

For someone who remembers so clearly, you got the name wrong.

I held my tongue and asked what I'd been wanting to ask since he spoke up. "What did you mean earlier?"

"Hm? What about?"

"You said an Escort Bureau was why things had gotten like this. In your words, Han bastards like us."

The old man gave me a blank look. "I said that? When?"

"What? You definitely—"

"Don't remember a thing."

Like hell you don't.

I caught on and sighed. "Food. Can you make us something now?"

"Of course. Pay me, and I'll make you anything."

At the word *food*, Taishan sprang up from where he'd been lying facedown on the table, looking close to death.

"Taishan wants five-spice pork!"

"So there's one fellow with more energy than he knows what to do with. I'll make chicken."

"Why chicken? Taishan doesn't want chicken! Five-spice pork!"

I had no idea how his request for five-spice pork had turned into chicken, but we needed to keep the old man happy. I called to the one person who could stop Taishan's fit.

"Ma Pyo. What are you doing?"

"It's Sama Pyo."

"Right, Sa-pyo."

"…Taishan. Enough. Sit down."

Sama Pyo glared at me before settling Taishan down. Meanwhile, the old man held out his hand as if it were the most natural thing in the world.

"What?"

"Payment up front."

"Ah."

"Let's see. One chicken per person is the minimum, so that's five chickens. At one silver nyang each… ten silver nyang altogether."

"…Ten silver nyang? Even if it's one nyang per chicken, that should be five silver nyang."

"Is that so? Then make it two nyang each."

"What?"

“I said two nyang per chicken.”

“…”

“If you don’t like it, spit on the floor and leave. There isn’t another village within a hundred li[2775], mind you.”

What a shameless racket. If this man had been born in Yongsan[2776] fifty years ago, he’d have ended up a landlord.

I wondered why we hadn’t met any bandits on the road. Turns out they were in the inn, not the mountains.

It was highway robbery, but now wasn’t the time to save money. I took ten silver nyang from the hefty expense pouch the Murim Alliance had given me and handed them over.

“Here. Ten silver nyang.”

“For a Han, you catch on quickly.”

Rustle.

The old man swept up the gleaming silver with a grin. “Now, what about liquor?”

“No, thank you.”

“Drink.”

“…”

“I said drink.”

I didn’t have the energy to argue. Looking glum, I opened my pouch again.

Our first meal in Nanman was remarkable for all the wrong reasons.

The chicken was so scrawny it looked malnourished. The strong liquor had clearly been opened and partly drunk by someone else.

It was astonishing that the old man charged us dozens of silver nyang for all this. More astonishing still was how much of the food and liquor he consumed himself.

“Burp. That was good.”

“…”

Why are you the one who had a good meal?

The question rose to my throat, but I swallowed it. We had bought information with our money and our meal.

“The Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau?”

“That’s right. As I recall, they definitely said they came from Sichuan. There was one woman, and with the other men, there were nearly thirty of them.”

[2775] In the Chinese setting, one li is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi). A hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi).

[2776] Yongsan is a Seoul district where decades of development drove real-estate values sharply upward.

The old man nodded, his face flushed with drink. “At first, nobody thought much of it. Han Chinese had come to Yeongin before, and their group wasn’t particularly large.”

But they had been wrong. His eyes reddened by drink, the old man slowly recalled what had happened.

“People from a nearby village held a feast to welcome them. By the next morning, every last one of the villagers had been slaughtered.”

“…!”

“Our village was spared, thank goodness. But when we checked later, we found that some two hundred people had died that night. Men, women, children, even the elderly. Not one survived. It was those Han bastards’ doing, of course.”

“Good grief.”

It was a shocking and horrific story. Only now did I fully understand the hostile looks and oppressive atmosphere that had been directed at us.

Two words came to mind.

Dark Heaven. And the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

It was hardly an overreaction to be troubled by one woman who had been part of the Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau.

I exchanged glances with the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, who had been listening with grim expressions, then took a sheet of paper from my Inventory.

“Sorry to interrupt, but could you look at this?”

“What is it?”

The paper I had taken out was a drawing. More precisely, it was a likeness of Honglan—or rather, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—created from the testimony and memories of several people, including me.

I showed it to him on the off chance he’d recognize her. His reaction was lukewarm.

“That artist is quite skilled. Who is she?”

“Hmm, no. I was just wondering if you recognized her.”

“Never seen the woman in that drawing. I’d remember a beauty like that. Old as I am, I’m still a man.”

It wasn’t the answer I’d hoped for, but I wasn’t too disappointed. Whatever sort of person the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was, she had a striking appearance. Ju Hwaran had hidden her face with the human-skin mask Song Ilseom made for her. The Demon Empress could have done the same in any number of ways.

It wouldn’t be strange at all for the Southern Heaven Demon Empress to have mastered an extraordinary disguise technique.

I turned back to the old man. “Where are those Central Plains people from the Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau now?”

The Quest required us to meet an agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, but if those people were still nearby, that changed things.

As if reading my thoughts, the old man asked, “Why? Thinking of going after them?”

“If we can.”

“Well, it’s an admirable thought, but it’ll be difficult. More than fifteen days have already passed.”

“If you know which way they went, or have some idea where they were headed, it’s worth a try.”

Every Fire Dragon Pavilion member here was formidable. Even Hyuk Mujin, the least skilled among us, was a Supreme First Rate master who had survived countless battles and brushes with death.

Yet despite my attitude, the old man merely let out a short laugh.

“It’s impossible.”

“Sir, I don’t think you understand—”

“I’m not the one who fails to understand. You are. Every one of those Central Plains people is dead.”

I froze. “What?”

“I mean exactly what I said. There were countless tribal warriors among those who suffered that calamity. Do you think people like that would have stood by and let themselves be slaughtered? The Central Plains people all died too. We found their bodies after they were poisoned with deadly venom and collapsed before they could get very far.”

“…!”

“No matter how skilled you are, you can’t chase them into the afterlife. And that goes for…”

His voice trailed off. A moment later, he sighed.

“…an agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion who’s already old as dirt.”

Gulp. Gulp.

The old man drained the last of the strong liquor and smiled at me.

“Good to meet you, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

Chapter 620

“Good to meet you, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

“…!”

A low voice burrowed into my ears, and a ripple of agitation spread through the room. But instead of being startled, I stared quietly at the old man.

As we talked, I’d begun to suspect he might be an agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.

He certainly fit the bill.

The old man before me was the owner of the meeting place Thousand-Faced Fox had told us about. And unlike the other non-Han locals, he hadn’t shown us any particular hostility.

Still, if you didn’t want to misstep, you had to knock on even a stone bridge before crossing it.

The System had warned me through the *Journey to Nanman* Quest, too. To stay alert at all times and act flexibly.

At least this time, I intended to follow that advice faithfully.

Shhhh.

Invisible internal energy spread through the inn, sealing it off from outside sound. Only then did I speak.

“Are you with the Hidden Shadow Pavilion?”

That was probably the question everyone wanted to ask.

With every eye on him, the old man rubbed a thumb over his filthy liquor cup.

“It’s been so long now since I was given my second name: Namho.”

Namho. Literally, “amber from the south.”

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion was an intelligence organization, so it gave its agents codenames to conceal their identities. The name Namho matched the information Thousand-Faced Fox had given us exactly.

“A certain fox said a fierce wind was blowing in Nanman.”

“Even if a typhoon rages, the Poison Flower rooted deep in the ground will not be shaken.”

That was the secret countersign too. Now I was sure.

I filled the old man’s cup—Namho’s cup—and said, “I was suspicious right up to the end. But you really are with the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.”

Namho drained his cup in one gulp and asked,

“Why? Did you never imagine that an agent of the Murim Alliance’s Hidden Shadow Pavilion might be one of the non-Han peoples?”

Just as Namho said, he was indeed not Han Chinese. His skin was dark from Nanman's fierce sun, and his distinctive features were plainly not Han Chinese. Anyone with half an eye could tell.

I gave a small nod and answered,

"To be honest, I can't say I didn't think that. It's just that you're so far from the Central Plains that it was hard to believe you were with the Murim Alliance's Hidden Shadow Pavilion. And from what I could sense, you didn't seem to have learned martial arts, either."

"Everyone has their own story. What matters is that most people think the way you do."

"And because they do, no one suspects you?"

"Who would suspect an old non-Han man who hasn't learned even a single martial arts move? It would be absurd."

Namho emptied the last bottle of liquor. Then he looked up as though something had just occurred to him.

"Oh. Are you blocking sound with your internal energy?"

"Of course. We can't let anyone outside hear us."

"Then lower it for a moment. There's something I absolutely must do."

Something he *had* to do?

What was it?

I wanted to ask in more detail, but Namho's expression was utterly serious. The moment I withdrew the internal energy sealing off the inn, Namho turned to Hyuk Mujin.

"You there. Is someone standing behind you?"

"Huh?"

Crash!

"Get the hell out of here, you rude Han bastards!"

It happened in an instant.

A liquor bottle struck Hyuk Mujin squarely in the back of the head, cracking his skull. The cheap bottle shattered, spraying fragments everywhere.

And Namho, the obvious culprit, started yelling at the top of his lungs.

"You bastards! Even tearing you apart wouldn't satisfy me! How dare you cause trouble here!"

"…!"

"…!"

Everyone, myself included, stared with our mouths hanging open at the sudden turn of events.

No one was more stunned than Hyuk Mujin. Clutching the back of his head, he gaped at Namho before bursting out, "Has this old man gone insane?"

"Yeah, I'm insane! You motherless, fatherless Han bastard!"

"Whoa. That's crossing a line. You're crossing a line!"

"You Han bastards crossed the line! Murdering people in Nanman wasn't enough, so now you're eating without paying?"

"No, fuck! What did you do with the silver coin I gave you earlier? Boil soup with it?"

"You didn't give me a single penny, so what kind of bullshit are you spouting? I took pity on you and gave you a meal after agonizing over it, and now get the hell out of my sight!"

Whoosh! Crash!

Bottles and bowls flew across the room. Within seconds, the inn was a wreck.

Namho screamed every insult he could think of and threw everything within reach. Then he looked at me, his lips moving just enough for me to read them.

Half a shichen[2777] from now. Meet me by the lakeside ten li[2778] away.

Only then did I understand the meaning behind his actions. I signaled to the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Ju Hwaran, Song Ilseom, and Sama Pyo caught on at once. They sprang up, overturned the table, and started smashing things. Each contributed a word.

"The food!"

"Dog!"

"Tastes like shit!"

Crash-crash-crash!

Crack! Rumble!

An unfortunate pillar broke apart, and the ceiling tilted.

Poison Flower Pavilion had already been on the verge of collapse. At this rate, it might as well change its name to Crumble Mansion.

I grabbed Hyuk Mujin, who was still shouting at Namho at the top of his lungs, and Taishan, who was shoveling the remaining food into his mouth, by the backs of their necks and ran.

"You crazy old man! Did you get this old by shoving years up your ass—urk!"

"No! Taishan's chicken leg! He was saving it!"

"Quit your bullshit and get out! All of you!"

Crunch!

Screams mingled with clouds of dust. I led the Fire Dragon Pavilion out through the chaos—and found a crowd of a hundred people waiting for us.

"The Han bastards are coming out!"

"They dared attack Elder Chao!"

[2777] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[2778] Using the Chinese li of approximately 500 meters (0.311 mi), ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 mi).

"Kill them!"

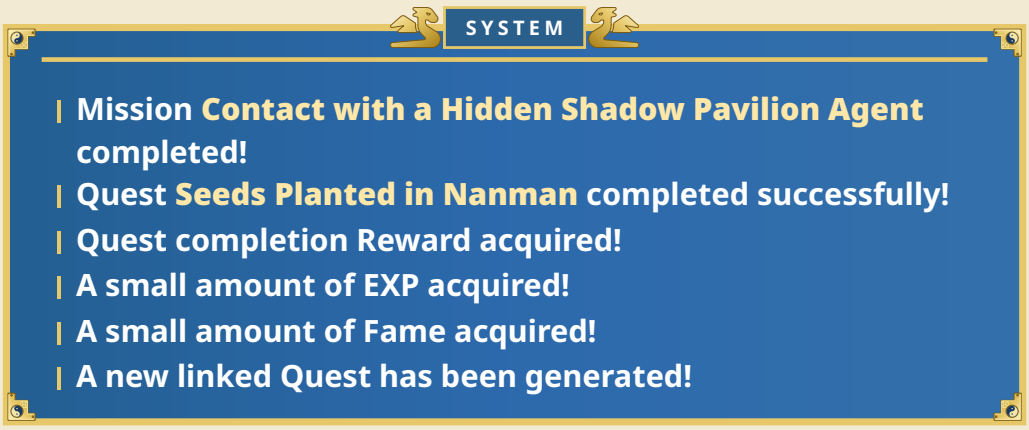
"No, throw them into the snake pit alive!"

Of course, there wasn't a single sane person among us who wanted to be thrown alive into a snake pit.

Swish! Thud!

I sighed and dodged a pickaxe. A belated System notification sounded in my ear.

Ding.



Okay, but where's the lakeside?

Namho appeared exactly half a shichen[2779] later, as promised. He carried a bundle in one hand. The other was wrapped in bandages.

"The pillar. Who broke it?"

"..."

"..."

"The inn I ran for forty years collapsed. I nearly died without leaving a will."

I tried to console him. "We didn't know that would happen. It'll be all right."

"You call that consolation? Does saying it's all right make it all right?"

"We'll compensate you properly later."

"That helps a little."

There was nothing like financial therapy. Namho's condition improved at once, and he turned to the rest of us.

"Try to understand what happened at the inn. I had to keep the villagers from getting suspicious. Things have been tense lately. If I'd defended you, they'd have started watching me too."

Hyuk Mujin replied sourly, "So you had to kill off my parents when they're both alive and well?"

[2779] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“I apologize for saying you had no mother or father. I had no choice.”

“How would you feel if someone said that to you?”

“I grew up alone. My parents died when I was little. I don’t even remember their faces.”

“Oh.”

You didn’t spend years as a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent without learning a thing or two. Namho had silenced Hyuk Mujin in a handful of words.

He took something from his bundle and held it out.

“What’s this?”

“A wooden map. For the past fifty-odd years, whenever I had time, I traveled around Nanman recording its terrain and the locations of its tribes in detail.”

Many years had passed since the Great Faction War, but not everyone had settled into peace. Namho had kept working, never forgetting his duty.

“Nanman is full of treacherous terrain, predators, and venomous beasts,” Ju Hwaran said. “That couldn’t have been easy. You must have worked terribly hard.”

Namho looked bitter.

“I only did what needed doing. Truthfully, even as I made this map, I hoped no one would ever need it.”

But peace had ended, despite his hopes.

Dark Heaven had shed the shell of the Demonic Cult and run rampant. Blood had stained every corner of the Central Plains, and that dark shadow was now stretching beyond the Central Plains into Nanman.

“I’ve already heard what’s happened,” Namho said. “The Pavilion Master is deeply concerned. Do you share those concerns?”

“Yes.”

I nodded without hesitation.

After everything that had happened around the Water God Dragon in Hubei, Nanman looked like a powder keg about to explode. It teemed with spiritual creatures, venomous beasts, and predators on a scale the Central Plains couldn’t begin to match.

“I assume you’ve heard about the rift.”

“Nanman is remote. Word hasn’t reached the people here, but I received a missive by messenger eagle. If the Pavilion Master hadn’t sent it, I wouldn’t have believed it.”

Anyone would have felt the same. Even people in the Central Plains who’d heard about the Water God Dragon dismissed it as a ridiculous rumor.

But it wouldn’t be long before these impossible things became reality—just as they had during the time people in the modern world called the Great Cataclysm.

“Dark Heaven is definitely targeting Nanman. Even if nothing has surfaced yet, something will happen before long.”

Namho stared at me with sunken eyes as I spoke with complete certainty.

“Long ago, I left Nanman of my own accord, traveling with a merchant caravan from the Central Plains. For the past fifty-odd years, though, I haven’t left this land once. And except for that recent incident, nothing has happened.”

“Do you mean the incident where the Central Plains people claiming to have come from the Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau attacked a nearby village?”

“Yes. The non-Han locals grew furious, and the atmosphere became dangerous, but that was all. It wasn’t common, but it wasn’t something that had never happened before, either.”

“I don’t know whether that incident had anything to do with Dark Heaven, but…”

I lowered my voice.

“What’s coming will be a tragedy far worse than that.”

“…!”

Namho’s eyes trembled.

This was his homeland, the place where he’d spent his life. After a brief silence, he spoke in a tired, elderly voice.

“Even as I packed my things and left my home, I didn’t want to believe it. But there’s no avoiding it now.”

He slung the bundle over his shoulder and started walking.

“Come. Wherever you’re headed, I’ll guide you.”

Chapter 621

“Come. Wherever you’re headed, I’ll lead the way.”

I looked at Namho, the elderly Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent, with admiration. Even at his age, his resolve was firm.

“You’d lead us even down the road to the afterlife. I don’t know how to thank you for such devotion, Elder Namho.”

“I didn’t say I’d go as far as the afterlife…”

“Your joints must ache these days, and I’m sure your memory isn’t what it used to be. Thank you for stepping forward anyway. You’ll be a great help to us.”

“…How very kind of you. Listening to you, I can feel strength and enthusiasm welling up through this old body of mine.”

“You’re welcome. No need to thank me.”

Namho stared at me sourly, then spoke.

“Where do you intend to go? I may have other ideas, but first I’d like to hear your destination.”

Our destination. Instead of answering, I glanced into the empty air.

There was nothing there, of course. But as had happened countless times before, I could read information in that empty space that no one else here could see.

SYSTEM

Quest
Nanman Beast Palace
The Nanman Beast Palace is one of the great powers of the Outer Lands. It lies in the deepest, most secluded part of Nanman, a land that is itself fiercely closed off.
The Murim of the Central Plains needs its help for the Great War to come. The time has come to awaken the beast that has long slept in the jungle.
Or perhaps… to save it from a danger that has yet to reveal itself.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung and Fire Dragon Pavilion members
Mission: Arrive at the Nanman Beast Palace (Incomplete)
Reward: Chain Quest
???
Failure: ???

The Chain Quest had updated right after we met Namho. It pointed in the same direction as my own thoughts.

“The Nanman Beast Palace. That’s where we’re going.”

At my belated answer, Namho nodded, his gaze deep and somber.

Nanman was vast and rugged beyond belief.

It covered less ground than Sichuan, but traveling through it took far more effort than traveling through the Central Plains.

“The Pavilion Master once told me that ten li[2780] in Nanman is like a hundred li in the Central Plains.”

Anyone who didn’t understand Namho’s words had never set foot in Nanman. In just half a day, the Fire Dragon Pavilion and I had learned exactly how shitty this place was.

Bzzzz. Smack!

“Mujin, what was that?”

“Nothing. Just a mosquito. Something stung the back of my neck, that’s all.”

“Oh, really? Be careful anyway. You never know. Want me to ask Elder Namho about it?”

“Come on, Captain. I’m not a child. Hyuk Mujin, a battle-hardened warrior who has fought countless fierce battles at the right hand of the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon! That’s me.”

Exactly one shichen[2781] later, the battle-hardened warrior Hyuk Mujin collapsed, vomiting.

“Bleeaagh!”

“Gasp, Mujin!”

“What happened?”

“Elder Namho! Mujin’s collapsed!”

“I may be old, but I can see that. Was he bitten by a mosquito?”

“Cough. Yes. About one shichen[2782] ago. It had blue stripes…”

“Blue stripes? And that was a shichen[2783] ago? An antidote! Bring an antidote, quickly!”

Fortunately, getting the battle-hardened warrior back on his feet wasn’t too difficult. I had the Myriad-Poison Ring, a divine artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan, and fifty antidotes I’d received as Quest rewards.

But that was no reason to relax.

[2780] A Chinese li is 500 meters (0.311 miles). Ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 miles); a hundred li is about 50 kilometers (31 miles).

[2781] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2782] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2783] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"They usually travel in swarms of dozens and even hunt predators. Another shichen[2784], and he'd be dead."

We set off again with Namho's stern warning in mind, heading deeper into secluded country to avoid the non-Han peoples who would charge at Han Chinese on sight.

Which meant heading somewhere even more dangerous.

"Taishan! Taishan's stomach hurts! Feels like it's tearing apart!"

"Elder Namho!"

"What did you eat this time?"

"Taishan was hungry. Picked red mushrooms off a tree and ate them."

"What kind of dog and pig bastard are you? After all the warnings I gave you, you ate blood-feeding fungus that even a tiger couldn't withstand just because you were hungry? Antidotes won't work on this!"

Namho flew into a rage, but his anger soon gave way to bewilderment. Taishan went into the brush to do his business and came back looking perfectly fine, despite eating a fungus that could kill a tiger.

"Taishan. Feels better after taking a dump. Fine now."

"…Is he even human?"

Sama Pyo considered Namho's earnest question for a moment before answering without much confidence.

"Probably."

"Taishan's stomach is empty again. Taishan is hungry."

"I swear by heaven and earth, if you ever eat another mushroom, you'll never have to worry about being hungry again."

"Oh. Taishan. Tempting."

"…I regret not learning martial arts. If I had, I'd have killed him with a single palm strike by now."

We left the old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent to his lament and kept walking.

At every turn, dense jungle and humid, sweltering heat awaited us. In the thick brush and swamps, the eyes of lurking predators glowed bright yellow.

Did we come to Nanman, or did we end up in the Amazon?

What a dogshit place.

There were more tigers than stray cats around a university neighborhood full of studio apartments, and crocodiles swarmed like tadpoles in Cheonggyecheon.

Even those were nothing compared to the strange poisonous flowers and plants that could do you in with their scent alone, or the bees with stingers bigger than their own bodies. At least the predators were large enough to spot.

[2784] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

There was a reason Hyuk Mujin had started complaining within a day or two of leaving Yeongin.

“To hell with the Nanman Beast Palace. I think I’ll be dead by the day after tomorrow.”

Maybe not the day after tomorrow, but in four days his life might well be in danger. He’d been poisoned about four times on the first day alone, and over the past two days he’d become skin and bones.

Shanxi Province counted as a borderland by Central Plains standards, but Nanman was far beyond anything we’d expected.

“Can’t we take another route? The roads might be run-down and rough, but compared to this, they’d be a walk down a flower-lined path.”

It wasn’t as if Nanman had no roads at all.

It was badly underdeveloped compared to the Central Plains, but I’d heard that the dozens, perhaps hundreds, of non-Han peoples settled here each had their own territory. Travel between them wasn’t particularly rare, so long as it didn’t cause disputes.

Despite Mujin’s desperate plea, Namho was firm.

“Impossible. You know why.”

“If it’s because the locals are dying to kill us, I’d rather face them head-on. And if we can talk things out, all the better.”

“Talk?”

Namho blinked at Mujin’s hopeful answer.

“Are you serious?”

“Of course.”

“An entire village vanished. Some two hundred people welcomed Han Chinese in good faith and were slaughtered, young and old alike. Do you think they’ll want to talk?”

“…No. I wasn’t actually serious.”

“Now you’re being honest. Good. Then shut up and walk.”

“Yes, sir.”

Look at him change his tune faster than light.

But this time, Namho was right about everything.

Fighting the non-Han peoples who attacked us would amount to declaring war on all of Nanman. They might snarl at one another ordinarily, but when an outsider appeared, they united as if their quarrels had never existed.

No wonder even the Demonic Cult failed to conquer all of Nanman during the Great Faction War.

The Cult's hundred thousand demonic soldiers had once swallowed half the world, yet all they managed here was to plant their flags on Nanman's outskirts before withdrawing.

They knew that going any deeper into a jungle rife with brutal endemic diseases, treacherous terrain, predators, and venomous beasts would cost more than it gained them.

And we can't exactly go around announcing who we are.

I doubted the non-Han peoples' hatred of Han Chinese would ease just because we told them our names. More importantly, Dark Heaven was lurking somewhere in Nanman.

They're definitely targeting Nanman. It's only a matter of time before something happens.

I was almost certain. We hadn't traveled like thieves in the night all the way from Henan, where the Murim Alliance headquarters stood, for nothing.

We'd had to reveal our identities to the bandits of Water Dragon Stronghold on our way here, but we'd made sure they kept quiet. It was also why we hadn't contacted the Emei Sect, the Qingcheng Sect, or the Sichuan Tang Clan, despite the ties we'd made on our last trip to Sichuan.

If we revealed ourselves to the non-Han peoples now, all that effort would go to waste.

Dark Heaven would realize an unseen dagger had come right up to its nose and rush its plans forward. Then the rift would open, and with it the door to disaster.

We can't reveal who we are until we reach the Nanman Beast Palace at the very least.

The Beast Miao King, lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, had fought in the Great Faction War. I'd also heard he was well disposed toward Jeok Cheongang and the Fire Gate Clan.

Given the importance of our business and his standing in Nanman, he was far more likely to listen than the other non-Han peoples, who were beside themselves with anger.

And thanks to those Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau bastards, we're getting shit splashed on us too.

One squid makes the whole fish market look bad, as they say. We'd been bundled together with them in the same Han Chinese package, and the Fire Dragon Pavilion's reputation—mine included—was shot.

I wasn't even Han Chinese.

…Does this make me a fake Han Chinese or what?

It was unfair as hell, but there was nothing I could do. I could tell the locals, "Actually, I'm not Han Chinese. I'm Korean. South, not North," and they wouldn't understand a word.

Besides, when I'd gotten homesick during training at Mount Jiuhua and drawn the Korean flag, Jeok Cheongang had said just one thing.

"Wudang?"

"No."

"It's obviously taiji. What kind of bullshit are you talking? Taiji means Wudang."

"Taiji means Korea."

"What's Korea?"

"That's… Never mind. You don't need to know, Old Master."

"Add two hundred geun[2785] of iron balls."

"…Two hundred geun[2786]? Why?"

"You don't need to know."

Just remembering it brought tears to my eyes.

It felt like only yesterday I'd been suffering in this distant land of another dimension. The miserable part was that the suffering never stopped.

"Whew."

At the sight of me sighing, Namho glared fiercely.

"What? Do you also want to go down there and settle things through conversation right now? Or would you rather throw down with the non-Han peoples?"

"…Where did that come from? I don't want to do either."

"That's a relief."

There had already been plenty of chances to throw down with someone, and there would be plenty more in the future. Even now, several predators were wandering around us, letting out their cries.

I scanned the dense jungle and swampland, then asked Namho, "How much farther?"

"Three days if we're quick. Six if we're not."

"That's a lot farther than I expected."

"Given that we have to stay out of sight, even that's quick."

Namho, whose face had aged noticeably, patted his lower back before starting to walk again.

"Don't slow down for a moment from here on. If we cross Ailao Mountain today, we can reach the Nanman Beast Palace in four days at the latest."

He was right.

Exactly four days later, as we crossed a high mountain peak, we spotted a massive structure in the distance, shrouded in thick clouds and mist.

[2785] A geun is a traditional Korean weight unit of 600 grams (1.32 pounds). Two hundred geun is 120 kilograms (about 264 pounds).

[2786] A geun is a traditional Korean weight unit of 600 grams (1.32 pounds). Two hundred geun is 120 kilograms (about 264 pounds).

“The Nanman Beast Palace…”

The voice that slipped from someone’s lips spread on a wind that had blown in from somewhere.

Chapter 622

Even counting only the time I had spent in Murim, well over a year had passed.

One unexpected incident after another had taken me out of Shanxi Province and sent me wandering from place to place. Along the way, I had met all kinds of people and visited the sects they belonged to.

But I could say this much for certain: none of those sects, however large or powerful, could compare to the sight before me.

"Huh."

"Holy…"

Exclamations broke out all around me.

I'd known the place covered an enormous area when I saw it from the mountain peak. I hadn't expected *this*.

As the clouds and mist cleared and we drew closer, my jaw dropped farther and farther.

Wait. This is a sect?

It was astonishing for two reasons. The first was its sheer size. The second was…

Nanman Beast Palace

A fence around the vast grounds, and a wooden sign someone had scrawled on in a clumsy hand.

Not a high, sturdy wall or an iron gate. A fence. Just a fence.

…Wait. This is a sect?

The thought was the same. The meaning was different.

The fence wasn't even intact.

I studied a half-collapsed stretch for a moment, then turned to Namho.

"Elder Namho, surely this isn't really…"

"You're asking if it's the Nanman Beast Palace?"

"Ah, yes."

I nodded, and Namho answered calmly.

"Can you read?"

"Of course."

"Then read that sign. No, perhaps I'd better read it for you."

He pointed at the clumsily lettered board.

"Nan. Man. Beast. Palace."

"…"

"That's what it says. The Nanman Beast Palace begins here."

I knew what the sign said. The problem was how far the place was from anything I'd imagined.

From above, I'd thought there must be an enormous building here. But up close, out of the mist, it was practically an empty field.

"Captain, shouldn't we call this the Nanman Ranch instead of the Nanman Beast Palace? All I see are fences."

Ju Hwaran looked around and nodded at Hyuk Mujin's dubious assessment.

"This is my first time here, so I can't say I know much about the Nanman Beast Palace, but… it does seem a little lacking for a palace."

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo, who had been watching in silence, each weighed in.

"There's certainly something strange about it."

"As Hyuk Mujin said, the lack of people bothers me. I don't see any other pavilions or buildings, either. What do you think, Taishan?"

"My lord. Taishan is hungry. Can Taishan eat that mushroom?"

Sama Pyo shook his head at once.

"No."

"Then the cow? That cow walking over there looks tasty."

"You're the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, aren't you? Do me a favor and shut that brute's mouth. If I hear one more word, I think I'll burst a blood vessel and die."

"…I understand."

"One more thing. Every blade of grass and every animal you can see belongs to the Nanman Beast Palace. Please remember that. And remember I'm about to burst a blood vessel."

Looking considerably older than he had a moment ago, Namho gave Sama Pyo that stern warning, then pointed across the vast grounds.

"I understand why you're confused, but I never said this place *was* the Nanman Beast Palace."

"What? You said exactly that a moment ago."

"No, I didn't."

"Ah. Have you gone senile?"

"…"

His expression darkened so quickly that it seemed certain. I gave him a sympathetic look.

"Oh dear. Still, I'm sure you'll be fine. Someone close to me also suffered from infirmities of old age, but they've almost completely recovered now."

"Three things. First, I do not suffer from the infirmities of old age. Second—and I ask only because you've made me curious—how did this acquaintance of yours recover?"

"Returned to Youth."

"…An excellent method. Apart from the fact that I'm an eighty-year-old man who's never learned martial arts."

"Isn't eighty when life begins?"

"I'd like to end *your* life here, but I lack the strength."

Namho swallowed his anger and went on.

"Third, what I said before still stands. I never said this place *was* the Nanman Beast Palace. I said the Nanman Beast Palace begins *here*."

"Oh."

Similar words, very different meanings. Now that I understood, I asked, "So what is this place?"

"That's right. This is one of the lands under the rule of the Nanman Beast Palace. Unlike the other regions of Nanman, it is directly administered by the Palace Lord. That may make it easier to understand."

"So it's similar to how the Emperor appoints vassal kings or City Lords throughout the realm. This place is like the capital of a country."

"Exactly. Of course, the Palace Lord doesn't have the authority of the Son of Heaven, and Nanman's tribal chiefs have more authority than City Lords."

Ju Hwaran, who had been listening, gave a quiet exclamation.

"Now that you mention it, I remember reading something like that in my grandfather's records. He wrote that Nanman was a single kingdom, and the Nanman Beast Palace was like an enormous ranch spanning five counties."

"As expected of the Escort King's granddaughter. But even Great Hero Ju Gongsan never crossed this fence. People who aren't of Nanman's ethnic groups aren't allowed inside."

"It's that strict?"

"It is."

If Namho was telling the truth, then even the Sichuan Tang Clan, a sect whose isolation was second to none in the world, would have to yield to the Nanman Beast Palace.

I clicked my tongue and stared beyond the endless line of fences and grasslands.

"But we need to get in."

"Yes."

"Is there another way? Since you're one of the local ethnic groups, perhaps you can enter…"

"I said outsiders aren't allowed in. I don't recall saying it was easy for the local peoples, either."

"Oh."

“Here, I’m nothing more than a powerless, ordinary old man of the Miao people. If Dark Heaven hadn’t extended its claws into the world, and if you people hadn’t come looking for me, I would have quietly ended my life… you bastard!”

I flinched at his sudden shout.

“Elder Namho, why are you calling yourself that? What’s wrong with quietly living out your days?”

“Not me! That bastard! Catch that fucking son of a bitch!”

At Namho’s frantic yell, we turned.

A huge backside was crawling over the fence. Beyond it, a yellow calf grazed peacefully.

“Oh. Oh, no.”

“Surely he isn’t…”

“When did that bastard get over there?”

“Young Hero Tae!”

“Taishan!”

Sama Pyo’s cry came last. Taishan flinched.

Moo?

The calf sensed something was wrong and jerked its head up. Taishan had somehow already drawn close. An exclamation mark seemed to pop into the calf’s large, clear eyes, and at the same time, its still-growing hooves struck the grass.

Pat-pat-pat!

A quick decision and an attempt to flee—but Taishan was a step faster.

“Beef! Stop right there!”

With that determined shout, his enormous body flew through the air.

The calf was no tiger or leopard. How was it supposed to evade a Peak master who’d decided to catch it?

Taishan landed with a heavy *thud*, and the calf pinned beneath him screamed.

Moooooo!

It was a plaintive cry, enough to bring tears to your eyes just hearing it. But after days of forced marches and meager rations, all it did was make Taishan’s mouth water.

“Taishan! Beef!”

“Get that bastard off it!”

Before Namho finished shouting, I’d vaulted the fence and reached Taishan.

Grab.

“Let go! Beef tartare!”

“Stop it, you heartless lunatic. Haven’t you seen *The Sound of the Bell*?”[2787]

[2787] *The Sound of the Bell* is a Korean documentary film about an elderly farmer and his ox.

"No!"

"…Ah."

Well, of course he hadn't.

That made sense, but it changed nothing. I seized him by the back of the neck and hauled him away.

His mountain-sized body toppled backward. The beef—no, the calf—scrambled to its feet and ran.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Grass flew up beneath its hooves, dust rising in its wake. Taishan watched its rump disappear beyond the pasture and muttered mournfully.

"No. Taishan's rump meat…"

Was this guy born in Majang-dong or something?[2788]

While I questioned his origins, Namho erupted.

"You brute!"

"Elder Namho, calm down. Please."

"How am I supposed to calm down right now? I repeatedly warned you not to touch anything in the Nanman Beast Palace's territory! And this hulking glutton of a bastard ignored every word an elder said and went and caused trouble?"

Sama Pyo hurried between Namho and Taishan.

"I'm sorry, Elder Namho. I looked away for just a moment, and… Taishan, apologize to him at once."

Taishan looked Namho straight in the eye.

"Taishan is hungry."

"That fucking bastard. Let go of my hand. Let go! Are you going to let go or not? Did you think I spent over fifty years getting bitten by mosquitoes in Nanman just to see this?"

Life really did begin at eighty. I only had to look at Namho, who had never learned martial arts yet was giving off an aura fierce enough to make even Jeok Cheongang yield to him for once, to know it.

The old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent, who had been raging like a live volcano, finally calmed down after fifteen minutes.

"Whew. I'm fine now. Let go of my hand."

"Are you sure?"

"My insides have turned a full circle, but I'm not about to die."

A 180-degree turn would have been a problem. A full 360? That was fine.

I nodded to Hyuk Mujin, and he released Namho's hand. Namho sighed, looking as though he were on his deathbed.

[2788] Majang-dong is a Seoul district known for its livestock and meat markets.

"At least nothing happened in the end. If someone from the Nanman Beast Palace had seen that, we'd have been in trouble before we even began."

At another sect in the Central Plains, someone might have thought, *It's only one cow.* But cultures and people differed. Just as nomads treasured their horses like their own lives, livestock was a valuable asset here, where the boundaries between tribes were sharply drawn and relations between them often strained.

It's called the Nanman Beast Palace, after all.

Even the name sounded animal-friendly. Namho had warned us from the start not to touch anything for a reason.

"So what do we do now?" Hyuk Mujin asked. "We can't wait here forever for someone to show up."

"Entering the Nanman Beast Palace's territory without permission would cause trouble. We'll have to find another way."

Namho reached into his bundle and took something out.

"What's that?"

"An emergency signal firework. If it goes off, someone should at least come out to investigate."

He smiled confidently and lit the fuse with his fire striker.

Crackle.

The fuse burned rapidly toward the end. Then, with a tremendous noise, the firework shot upward.

Fwoooosh—boom!

The problem was that the firework's burst came down on the pasture instead of exploding in the air.

"…Huh?"

"…Huh?"

Whoooosh—roar!

The pasture was engulfed in flames alongside the stunned voices of the others.

I watched the livestock flee in every direction and muttered, "…Someone will definitely come out now."

"…That wasn't supposed to happen."

Wasn't supposed to happen, my ass. We were fucked.

It was then, as I stared miserably at the burning pasture, that it happened.

Roooar!

A savage roar rang out, and a figure appeared beyond the hill on the far side of the flames.

Chapter 623

The young man's brown skin was handsomely tanned, and fine muscles stood out across his lean frame. At a glance, his features marked him as different from the Han Chinese of the Central Plains.

He looked down the hill and wondered,

…What happened here?

It was a reasonable question. A vast pasture was burning before his eyes.

Even now, the rapidly spreading flames were belching endless clouds of black smoke, while cows, sheep, horses, and other livestock fled frantically through the chaos.

Grrrr.

A low growl and tremor suddenly reached him from below. The young man gently stroked the snow-white mane of the white tiger beneath him.

"It's all right. It's okay."

Grrk.

"You're really angry, aren't you?"

Feelings were not conveyed through words alone.

Though one was human and the other a beast, they had spent enough years together to understand each other from the slightest gesture or change in a growl.

The young man met the white tiger's blue gaze and nodded.

"That's right. We'll put out the fire first. We can punish the intruders afterward."

Left alone, the flames would spread beyond control and reduce the entire pasture to ash.

The land could be restored, of course, but they still had to save the livestock that would otherwise be swallowed by the flames and die.

After that…

How dare they?

It was bad enough that the intruders had entered the Nanman Beast Palace's territory without permission. They had set it on fire, too. They would answer for that.

The young man glared at the indistinct figures beyond the distant, acrid smoke and stroked the white tiger's mane.

The white beast understood and shot forward like the wind.

Kraaaar!

Its thunderous roar carried through the flames.

It happened in the blink of an eye.

A white tiger and a non-Han young man had suddenly appeared on the hill, then began rushing about in every direction as though they had become one body.

Whoosh—roar!

I think I saw this in an educational comic when I was little.

Was this what they called a backfire?

Fire met fire. They devoured each other until one went out. The backfire the young man had skillfully set worked remarkably well.

As the flames quickly died down as if nothing had happened, I stepped forward to lend a hand out of sheer conscience.

Boom!

I threw a short, sharp punch. The flames wavered like a candle in the wind…

…and then grew even larger.

ROOOOAR!

“Good grief.”

What the hell?

Namho shouted at me, his voice rising almost to a scream.

“You lunatic! What did you do?”

“…Are you really one to talk, Old Man Nam? The man who farted is getting angry. You set the fire, and now you’re complaining to me?”

“I didn’t know that would happen!”

“Neither did I.”

“Is that what matters? Put the fire out first… Oh! Oh, oh! Behind you! Behind you!”

ROOOOAR!

“Don’t be so dramatic. It’s still fine.”

The flames had not grown *that* much stronger, but we did need to put them out quickly.

In my haste, I struck again and again with my palms at the swelling fire, without stopping to think.

A moment later, it came to me.

Oh, right.

The palm technique I had just used was called the Flame Divine Palm.

Fwooooooosh!

A moment ago, I could not have said the flames had grown that much stronger. Now I could say it with confidence.

They had grown a hell of a lot stronger.

In a way, it was almost miraculous. Flames that had been on the verge of dying were now roaring several times larger than before.

To the livestock fleeing in every direction, of course, it must have looked like hell.

"…Uh."

I stared from the near-inferno around me to my palms and back. Then I looked up and met two pairs of eyes glaring at me through the flames.

They belonged to the white tiger from the hill and the young man riding it. Their eyes were different colors, and they were different species, but they had one thing in common.

They were both pissed as hell.

"You bastard! What do you think you're doing?"

Kraaaar!

The kid looked young, yet he was speaking casually to me on our first meeting.

He had crossed a line, certainly. Then again, I had burned the line down. As a civilized man of the twenty-first century, I calmly and politely reassured them.

"I don't know who you are, but don't worry. I'll take care of it."

Of course, there was no guarantee they would feel reassured just because I said so. As demonstrated by the immediate response.

"No! Don't!"

Kraaaar!

I gently reasoned with the man and tiger shouting in unison.

"It's okay. I can do this. More importantly, could you quiet the tiger down a little?"

"No, you bastard!"

Kraaaar!

"Don't do it?"

"Don't do it!"

KRAAAAR!

Hmm. Opposition as fierce as the fire itself. But I shook my head.

"No. I'm doing it. I believe in myself."

"You crazy Han Chinese bas—!"

Kraaaar…!

Before either of them could finish, I struck with both palms at lightning speed.

Whoooosh—boom!

Two streams of mighty palm force shot through the air, splitting apart and bursting through the rolling waves of fire.

But if I stopped there, the flames would only surge higher. I would be repeating the same mistake.

Without hesitation, I fired off one palm force after another.

Boom! Boom!

The reason people had trouble putting out fires was simple.

They either lacked enough water, or they lacked wind strong enough to snuff the flames out like candles.

So all you needed was more water or stronger wind. In this case, I went with the latter.

Boom!

The final palm force I sent out was especially powerful.

A typhoon-like wind swept across the pasture. The fleeing livestock lifted briefly off the ground, and grass and trees alike were flattened.

And then…

Whoosh.

The flames spreading in every direction died down in an instant.

All that remained were small embers burning like a campfire and patches of pasture reduced to black ash.

A young man and a snow-white tiger stared at it all in a daze.

"What… What is this?"

Grrrr?

Two pairs of eyes turned to me in disbelief.

I walked over to the last ember nearby, ground it out beneath my foot, and shrugged.

"I told you. I can do it."

…!

…!

The young man stared at me in pure astonishment. Then he aimed the spear in his hand at me.

"I am Yayul Mok of the Nanman Beast Palace. Who are you?"

So he was from the Nanman Beast Palace. No surprise there.

I nodded and was just about to answer when an elderly voice suddenly rang out from behind me.

"He is Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

I turned. The members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion had come up behind me, with Namho at their head.

"In the Central Plains, they call him the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, the foremost young prodigy of his generation. He is also the Pavilion Master of the Fire Dragon Pavilion, which belongs to the Murim Alliance."

I did not know whether my name and sobriquet had reached Nanman.

But at the very least, the non-Han young man in front of me—Yayul Mok—seemed to understand the words Namho had added perfectly.

"The Murim Alliance…"

He murmured the words and stroked the white tiger's mane. After watching its growls subside, he lowered his spear and turned away.

"Follow me. Since the Murim Alliance has been mentioned, I will let this go for now. But don't do anything as foolish as that again."

Namho shrugged.

"It was an accident. But I'll keep it in mind."

"You had better, unless you want to die a sudden death."

I watched Yayul Mok ride ahead on the white tiger, then gave Namho a sour look.

"That kid's rude. I know setting the fire was wrong, but still."

"Hey, Han Chinese. I can hear you."

Grrrr.

"I meant for you to hear me, punk."

"What?"

"Is that any way to speak to an elder? Don't you have a grandfather?"

For a moment, anger flashed across his face. He glared at me, then turned away again. Walking behind me, Namho gave me a flat, unimpressed look and said,

"Watch your tongue."

"I was taking your side, Old Man Nam. Telling someone who could drop dead any day that he might 'die a sudden death'? Who says that?"

"Since when could I drop dead any day…? Forget it. I should never have expected anything from you. Do you have some illness that'll kill you on the spot if you go even one day without stirring up trouble?"

"Do you have a disease that'll make you senile if you don't set fire to a pasture owned by the Nanman Beast Palace?"

"…"

"Take a good look at yourself before I confiscate your walking stick for three months."

Namho sighed, having come off much worse in that exchange.

"All right. I admit it. This was clearly my mistake. It was something I had kept for more than fifty years, so I should have been more careful handling it."

"Nice to see you admit it so readily. The pasture's still nice and hot, though."

"…My bones ache every time you speak. Still, be a little more careful with that young man."

"Why?"

"Why else? You heard his name. Yayul Mok."

"Yayul Mok, Yayul Mosquito—what am I supposed to…?"

I trailed off. Something I had forgotten was hovering just out of reach.

Yayul Mok. Yayul Mok…

After thinking it over carefully, I turned to Ju Hwaran and asked,

“Excuse me, Young Lady Ju.”

“Yes?”

“What was the name of the lord of the Nanman Beast Palace again?”

“You mean the Beast Miao King?”

“Yes.”

The Beast Miao King, lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, led the Miao people, one of Nanman’s most powerful tribes. Despite his non-Han origins, he also held a place among the Ten Kings, albeit the lowest.

Hwaran smiled and answered kindly.

“Yayul Cheok.”

“Ah. Right.”

“Yes. Yayul is his family name. It’s a rare surname that you don’t often encounter even in Nanman.”

“Then that rude friend of ours must have the surname Ya. And his given name is Yulmok.”

“Forgive me, but are you hoping that’s true?”

“Hmm. What if I am?”

Hwaran was about to answer when the forest blocking Yayul Mok’s path far ahead began to shake.

Rustle. Crackle!

I swear I had not seen so many different animals gathered in one place since I went to the zoo at seven years old.

Jaguars and tigers covered in black fur, leopards, even elephants.

The non-Han men and women riding the beasts spotted Yayul Mok. They hurriedly dismounted and prostrated themselves.

“Young Palace Lord!”

“Are you unharmed?”

“We received an urgent report that a fire had broken out. If Young Palace Lord continues acting so recklessly, the Palace Lord will be terribly worried… But who are these people?”

Dozens of pairs of eyes, human and beast alike, turned toward us.

I quietly considered what they had called him. Then I recalled asking him whether he had a grandfather.

I edged up beside Yayul Mok, draped an arm over his shoulders, and said,

“We’re friends. Right, Mok?”

“…”

“Hey. Smile.”

Chapter 624

Ju Hwaran told me that her grandfather, the Escort King Ju Gongsan, had once said this about the Nanman Beast Palace:

> "Nanman is practically a kingdom, and the Nanman Beast Palace is a vast ranch encompassing five counties."

The Escort King had traveled the Four Seas and Five Lakes and the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes. He had been right.

The territory directly ruled by the Nanman Beast Palace stretched across five counties. In sheer area, even the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families of the Central Plains could not compare.

Direct rule versus indirect rule, I suppose.

The Son of Heaven ruled the Central Plains, but in Nanman, the Nanman Beast Palace held supreme authority. It might not surpass the great orthodox factions in martial power, but its influence here was bound to be far greater.

If there was one thing the Escort King had gotten wrong…

This isn't a ranch. It's a safari.

I had never seen such a jumble of animals, plants, temperatures, and terrain in one place.

We followed Yayul Mok and his subordinates across grasslands, through jungles, and over mountains and rivers. I could only shake my head.

"What the hell is wrong with this weather?"

Ju Hwaran, riding to my right, answered my mutter.

"One mountain holds four seasons, and ten li bring a different sky.[2789] It's a saying that describes Nanman's unpredictable nature quite well."

"Having seen it for myself, I can't argue. Young Lady Ju, what made you take an escort job to a place like this?"

"I didn't know it would be this extreme, either. I've accompanied my father on escort journeys before, but this is my first time going so deep into Nanman."

A thick fur pelt was draped over her shoulders. She smiled, and a cloud of white breath escaped her lips.

Most people associated Nanman with jungles. Like anyone else from the Central Plains, I had thought the same.

But this damned land had somehow packed frigid, temperate, subtropical, and tropical climates together like apartments along a hallway.

"At this point, it's practically cursed land."

[2789] A Chinese *li* is about 500 meters (0.311 miles); ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 miles).

"…Watch your mouth."

If Hwaran was on my right, Namho was on my left.

The elderly Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent was riding a black panther with one of Yayul Mok's subordinates. He hunched low to avoid the branches but still found room to glare at me.

"I'm sure they'd love to hear you say that. Don't you think?"

"So what? It's true. Besides, I'm speaking Han Chinese. They can't understand me."

A few dozen feet ahead, Yayul Mok spoke without warning.

"I'd prefer it if you kept that mouth of yours shut."

"…That was Han Chinese."

"…Han Chinese?"

How the hell did he pull that off?

I felt like a cardsharp caught dealing from the bottom of the deck at a flower-card game.[2790] Yayul Mok's Han Chinese was halting but unmistakable. Namho and I exchanged a look before I asked, "Did you study Han Chinese?"

"A little. I lost interest and quit soon afterward."

"Oh, really? Only a little? And you quit that quickly?"

Yayul Mok answered my hopeful question with a stony face. "I still understand it well enough. Words like 'cursed land,' for example."

"…"

"We'll arrive soon, and then you can leave this cursed land. Until then, I'd appreciate it if you stayed quiet."

There was nothing I could say to that. I shut my mouth, and Namho smiled with the wisdom of a sage.

"Well done. Very well done. Thanks to you, the Nanman Beast Palace and the Murim Alliance should be able to join hands with ease."

"You make that sound like an insult. Still, you heard the good news."

"It's good news for Dark Heaven. The Murim Alliance's foremost young prodigy came to propose an alliance, asked the Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace whether he had a grandfather, and called Nanman a cursed land. Come to think of it, are you with Dark Heaven?"

"Do I look like a member of Dark Heaven?"

"No. But I'll admit I'm starting to wonder. Enough nonsense. What's this good news I haven't heard?"

I answered with confidence. "We'll be at the Nanman Beast Palace soon."

"God damn it…"

"Hey, don't swear."

[2790] Flower cards (*hwatu*) are Korean playing cards used in gambling games such as go-stop. Being caught dealing from the bottom of the deck echoes the Korean gambling film *Tazza*.

"Do I look like I can help swearing right now? That A-Gwi bastard[2791] they call Taishan—or Geumsugangsan[2792] or whatever his name is—is one problem, but in my opinion, you're no less troublesome, Pavilion Master. You're already acting like this before we arrive. What are you going to do if your particular brand of insanity flares up when you actually come face-to-face with the Beast Miao King?"

"'Insanity' is a bit harsh. I may look reckless, but I know when I can stretch my legs. And Taishan may be lacking in certain areas, but he's a major asset. When the time comes, he'll pull his weight. You don't need to worry so much."

At that moment, a mournful animal cry rose behind us, followed by a frantic shout.

Gwooooooo!

"Y-Young Palace Lord! This huge Han bastard is biting my bear's ear off!"

"Taishan! Bear meat!"

"Captain!"

"Taishan! Stop! Stop eating!"

"Seize that Han bastard!"

I glanced back as we rode, then added, "Of course, his appetite is a problem."

"For fuck's sake. There's appetite, and then there's appetite. Is that thing a beast or a person?"

I couldn't argue. Lately, I'd begun to suspect Taishan might be some unknown creature occupying the space between human and beast.

Fire Dragon Pavilion. Are we going to be all right like this?

Taishan was chewing on the ear of the bear he'd been riding. Sama Pyo was trying to put a stop to his subordinate's animal abuse, while the bear howled in pain and made it abundantly clear that it refused to carry passengers any longer.

I was watching them when Yayul Mok spoke with a sigh.

"We're here. Please stop this and get off already."

He was right. The chill in the air had vanished. Humid, oppressive heat surrounded us now, and a dense tropical rainforest stood ahead.

Beyond it…

Rumble, rumble.

An iron gate covered in vines and tree trunks swung open, revealing countless pavilions and houses.

[2791] A-Gwi is the ruthless gambler villain of the film *Tazza*. His name, *agwi*, also means a ravenous "hungry ghost".

[2792] *Geumsugangsan* literally means "beautiful mountains and rivers," a Korean expression for a scenic landscape.

[2793] A Chinese *li* is about 500 meters (0.311 miles); ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 miles).

This was a glimpse of the Nanman Beast Palace. Tens of thousands of li[2793] from the Central Plains, in the deepest and most secluded part of Nanman, its people had built a kingdom of their own.

Any family or sect of a certain size, including the Jin Family of Taiyuan, generally divided itself into an Outer Hall and an Inner Hall. The division gave it an organizational structure and lines of defense in case enemies attacked.

But the Outer Hall of the Nanman Beast Palace was far larger than that of an ordinary sect.

This is practically a city.

The Escort King had called it a kingdom for good reason.

Unusual houses and countless other buildings, unlike anything commonly seen in the Central Plains, caught my eye. People were haggling at what looked like a market on one side of the street. Nearby, children of six or seven laughed and played with young beasts.

People, buildings, commerce, workshops—there was so much of everything that the place looked like the capital of a small nation. Hyuk Mujin couldn't close his mouth.

"Wow. I thought I'd seen a lot, but this is beyond anything I imagined. Captain, do you see that? It's incredible."

"It is. But there's something even more incredible. Want to know what?"

Hyuk Mujin kept looking around as he asked, "What?"

"Us."

"Ah."

"Now that you get it, close your mouth and stop gawking. We're attracting enough attention already."

Judging by the settlement immediately visible before us and its sheer size, the Outer Hall alone probably contained several thousand households.

Moreover, the Nanman Beast Palace was located in the deepest part of Nanman, and outsiders were strictly forbidden from entering. Naturally, we stood out like a handful of pebbles among them.

Quite a few of them were probably seeing Han Chinese for the first time.

Making a fuss wouldn't help us, especially with the mood like this.

"Are those Han Chinese? They look like us, but a little strange."

"Shh. Don't even make eye contact. Haven't you heard what happened in the north? A bunch of Han Chinese slaughtered an entire Miao village. Those people might be with them."

“Of course I heard about it. But what could those bastards possibly do here? They look like the Young Palace Lord captured them.”

“They don’t look like prisoners to me… Anyway, what brings Han Chinese all the way here?”

Their languages varied as much as their clothing and appearances. Hwaran, Namho, and I could understand what they were saying, and we spoke among ourselves in low voices.

“Looks like word has already spread.”

“I can only understand the Miao and Bai languages, but the mood here seems tense overall.”

“It happened only a few days ago. Tribes clash dozens of times a year, but an incident involving outsiders might happen once in a decade, if that. Of course word spread quickly.”

If we had built up a good reputation, we might have been welcomed wherever we went. But the massacre of the Miao village about a month earlier had produced the exact opposite result.

Hyuk Mujin shrank back, taking the hint, and grumbled.

“Those lunatics. The Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau, or whatever they were called. Why did they have to commit such an atrocious crime in Nanman of all places…?”

“I wonder. Why did they?”

Sama Pyo had cut in. He continued in an amused tone. “And why now, of all times? That’s worth thinking about. I suspect our friend there has been thinking the same thing I have for a while. Am I right?”

Song Ilseom answered evenly. “Yes, but no.”

“…What does ‘yes, but no’ mean?”

“It means that whatever I may think, I don’t want to talk to you. So don’t.”

“You’re pettier than you look. Well, if that’s how it is.”

I gave Sama Pyo a warning look. He raised an eyebrow, then backed off first.

Their feud aside, I had been carrying the same question throughout the journey.

The Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau.

Coincidence or design, the timing of the massacre was suspicious. It was too early to say what the answer was.

Still, have we avoided the worst?

Before meeting Yayul Mok, I’d been a little worried. No, very worried. I’d feared that Dark Heaven’s scheme had already begun and the Nanman Beast Palace had become a hellscape.

Of course, our image as Han Chinese had plummeted to the level of a pro-Japanese corporation, but the mere fact that nothing had happened yet was more than enough.

Even if we have to take some abuse, this is much better.

As I thought that, a strange sense of déjà vu made me lift my head.

This is…

The others might not have noticed, but I could feel it: the flow of air had grown heavier so gradually that the change was easy to miss. Beyond the crowd's noise and the countless signs of life around us, someone's aura was pouring out in rough waves.

I followed it with my eyes.

An old man sat atop a flight of vine-covered steps. His upper body was bare, his frame massive and muscular.

I knew who he was before he opened his mouth.

The Beast Miao King.

It was him.

Chapter 625

People have something called an aura.

Some people's auras are so faint and hazy they can barely be felt. Others are powerful and rough as waves, overwhelming anyone who faces them.

The Beast Miao King, Yayul Cheok, belonged to the latter sort.

Whoosh.

Yayul Cheok slowly rose to his feet, like a mountain beginning to move.

Though he was well over eighty, the muscles covering his body were as solid as armor. He walked without hesitation, his half-gray beard billowing like a lion's mane.

Thud. Thud.

Everyone could see him now as he came down the vine-covered steps, trampling them beneath his bare feet.

Yayul Mok and his guards immediately dismounted and dropped to one knee. It was their way of showing respect to the lord of the Nanman Beast Palace.

"Greetings, Palace Lord."

The Beast Miao King stared intently at Yayul Mok.

"You ran off again without a word."

"There was a fire in the northeastern pasture. I happened to be nearby…"

"Did you put it out?"

"Yes."

"And the culprit?"

The question was clearly for Yayul Mok, but the Beast Miao King was looking at me.

I met the fierce light in his tiger-like eyes and stepped forward.

"'Culprit' would be putting it a bit strongly. There was a little mistake."

"It has been a long time since I've seen Han Chinese. Are you the culprit who started the fire?"

Before I could answer, he went on in a growling voice.

"Think carefully before you answer. Nanman's laws are not merciful."

I thought for a moment. "What's the punishment for something like this?"

"That depends on the damage. In serious cases, the offender is fed to wild beasts. Or thrown into a pit full of venomous beasts."

"What about minor cases?"

"Hanged from a vine."

"That's minor?"

"Of course. The body remains intact."

"Ah."

I nodded, stepped casually aside, and introduced someone.

"Ta-da. He's the culprit, actually."

An ordinary person might have panicked, but a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent with fifty years of experience was made of sterner stuff. Namho spoke calmly.

"Are you fucking insane?"

"I'm not wrong, am I?"

"You fucking bastard…"

Namho was about to launch into a full stream of abuse when the Beast Miao King cut in, his voice rough.

"So you mean to abandon your companion to save your own skin."

"Hmm. I think you've misunderstood. I never said I was abandoning him."

"A misunderstanding?"

"I'm just getting the facts—no, setting the record straight. We haven't known each other long, but he's a good man. And there's the Murim Alliance's reputation to consider."

I had brought up the Murim Alliance deliberately. He could have let the matter drop there, but the fierce light in his eyes did not dim.

"Once you enter Nanman, you follow Nanman's laws. What if one of you must take responsibility?"

"If you insist…"

I scratched the back of my head.

"Wouldn't we have to stop that somehow?"

At that moment—

Whoom!

The air around us vanished.

Before the short, heavy sound of air splitting could even be heard, a single punch shot toward me. It carried enough force to resemble a battering ram, and I crossed both arms in front of myself.

Boom!

A deafening roar rang out as though the sky itself had split open, and the shock wave from the collision swept in every direction.

The tremendous force drove me back a full ten feet.[2794] I sighed.

"Will that do?"

The Beast Miao King asked, his eyes emitting a glacial light.

"What do you mean?"

"Our first greeting."

[2794] The source uses one *jang*, a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

"What?"

"Before coming to Nanman, someone told me something. The Beast Miao King may look ignorant and reckless, but he's actually warmhearted and loves playing pranks. So take him in stride and get along with him."

"…!"

"…!"

The Fire Dragon Pavilion members' reaction—standing there with their mouths hanging open—was nothing compared to what came next.

Yayul Mok, the Young Palace Lord, and his guards stared at me in shock before reaching for their weapons at lightning speed.

But before they could act, the Beast Miao King, whose lips had been twitching at my words, burst into laughter.

"Ha ha ha ha! Old Master Jeok hasn't changed a bit."

I rubbed my stinging forearms. "He's as hale as ever."

"I heard he'd taken a Disciple, but I didn't expect to meet you so soon."

He looked me over with fresh interest, then grinned.

"Good to meet you. This old man is Yayul Cheok."

With anyone else, things might have been different. But before he was lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, he was someone Jeok Cheongang knew.

I clasped my hands respectfully toward the Beast Miao King.

"Jin Taekyung, nineteenth successor of the Fire Gate Clan, pays his respects to Great Hero Yayul Cheok, the Beast Miao King."

"Good! Ha ha ha!"

He laughed again, rough and hearty, then spoke with unmistakable warmth.

"We have much to discuss. Follow me."

Everyone stared after him as he strode away, then turned to me. Their faces all asked the same question.

I shrugged. "He's pretty close with my master."

As expected, life was all about school ties, regional ties, and blood ties.

The Beast Miao King looked happy. No, he definitely was happy.

Jeok Cheongang had told me he was usually cheerful, but as he sat in the Nanman Beast Palace's main hall telling old stories, he looked like an oversized child.

"I remember the day I first met Old Master Jeok. He took one look at me and hit me with a Flame Divine Palm."

"…According to the Old Master—no, according to my master—he didn't actually let it fly. He said he only almost did."

“No, he definitely hit me. It knocked the breath out of me and scared the shit out of me.”

The Sect Leaders and Family Heads of the great factions I’d met so far generally maintained some dignity. The Beast Miao King walked around in nothing but tiger-skin pants and didn’t give a damn about dignity.

As proof, he showed me the mark of the Flame Divine Palm stamped into his side and added casually,

“Quite a first meeting. I shit blood twice, went back to see him, and he poured me a drink to disinfect the wound. What a hearty man.”

“…Ah. Right.”

I wondered whether *hearty* meant what I thought it did. But if the man who’d been hit was fine with it, what could I say?

Besides, criticizing Jeok Cheongang would be like spitting in my own face.

“I regretted not seeing Old Master Jeok after the Great Faction War ended. Meeting his Disciple like this is a pleasure. Do you drink?”

“Of course I do, but I can’t right now.”

“Why not?”

“Something’s more urgent than a drink.”

If the world had been at peace, I would gladly have made a night of it. I would have toasted the Beast Miao King, shouted, “Yayul Cheok’s favorite—random games!” and gotten all the people of other ethnicities completely wasted on drinking games.

But not now.

“This time, I didn’t come as my master’s Disciple. I came as the Pavilion Master of the Murim Alliance.”

The smile on the Beast Miao King’s lips faded a little.

“Because of Dark Heaven?”

“So you know about them.”

“I received a messenger eagle concerning it. Since we’re tens of thousands of li[2795] from the Central Plains, the message arrived late. But it’s not as though I know nothing about the situation in the Central Plains.”

“If you don’t mind my asking, when did you receive it?”

“Let me think. More than a month ago now, I believe.”

Considering the distance between Henan and Nanman, as well as the timing, the letter must have been sent before the formation of the Murim Alliance, an event called the Mount Song Resolution.

[2795] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

As many sects as possible had needed to attend the Mount Song Resolution, and Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion Thousand-Faced Fox was not the kind of person who would send a letter without taking even that into account.

Which meant…

"The Nanman Beast Palace refused to join the alliance."

There had been time to send a reply, or to bring some of the people of Nanman to Mount Song. But the fact that the Nanman Beast Palace had sent no response to the Murim Alliance could only be interpreted as a polite refusal.

The Beast Miao King remained silent for a moment before abruptly opening his mouth.

"It was not an outright refusal. We simply haven't reached a decision."

"But surely, Palace Lord, that decision is yours to—"

He raised a hand, cutting me off. Stroking his mane-like beard, he spoke again.

"Old Master Jeok's Disciple. No, Jin Taekyung, was it?"

"Yes."

"I have a question for those you brought with you. Do you know who I am?"

The group hesitated. Hyuk Mujin was the first to meet his gaze, and he swallowed hard before answering.

"You're Great Hero Yayul Cheok, the Beast Miao King. A Supreme Peak master and one of the Ten Kings."

"Correct. The woman beside you. Yes, you."

Ju Hwaran answered at once. "As everyone knows, you're the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace."

"That is also correct. But it is not the answer I want. This time, you beside her—tell me."

Before anyone could stop him, Taishan blinked his enormous eyes.

"Taishan. Hungry."

You bastard, Taishan. You answering-machine bastard. You fucking bastard…

The answer was so far from anything I'd expected that even the Beast Miao King looked taken aback.

"Who is he?"

I thought for a moment, then answered honestly. "I'm not really sure anymore."

"What a strange fellow. Then let the old man beside him answer."

Namho, who had been firing a rapid stream of profanity at Taishan in a low voice, opened his mouth.

"You are the Great Chieftain who leads the Miao people."

"Yes."

The Beast Miao King nodded.

“I am the Great Chieftain who represents countless Miao people. I gathered them under one banner and became the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace with the support of the other tribal chiefs. Mok, do you know how many tribes exist in our land?”

Yayul Mok, who had been standing quietly at attention, answered.

“If we include all of Nanman, there are thirty-two tribes, including four great tribes such as the Miao people.”

“Yes. That is the Nanman Beast Palace.”

I understood what the Beast Miao King was getting at. So did everyone else in the hall.

Except Taishan, of course.

“Are you saying…”

“Before I am Palace Lord, I am the Great Chieftain of the Miao people. And the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace is not a king.”

He couldn’t make every decision alone.

The Nanman Beast Palace was certainly like a separate kingdom, cut off from the Central Plains. But that kingdom was made up of an alliance of large and small tribes.

Why tell us so openly, though?

Are the other tribes opposed, while the Beast Miao King himself is considering agreeing to join the alliance?

I was about to ask when a quiet voice came from beyond the firmly shut doors of the main hall.

“Palace Lord, may I speak with you for a moment?”

Chapter 626

"Palace Lord, may I speak with you for a moment?"

A low, rigid voice came through the crack between the closed doors.

Everyone turned toward the doors behind us. But in that brief instant, I caught a change in two faces.

The Beast Miao King. And Yayul Mok.

We outsiders were stones that had happened to roll in from elsewhere. Those two were rooted so deeply in Nanman that they were more like its indispensable core.

I didn't know who the voice belonged to, but the way their eyes darkened was answer enough.

They're not exactly on smiling terms.

Just as I reached that conclusion, the Beast Miao King met my gaze and gave a quiet laugh.

"What an interesting fellow."

"Pardon?"

"It's nothing. Just something that slipped out."

As if it were nothing. Anyone could see it was something.

But the Beast Miao King gave a small wave of his thick hand, as if telling me not to ask any further, then addressed everyone—including me.

"I'm sorry, but another guest has arrived. Could you give us some privacy? We still have time. Rest from your journey, and we can talk properly afterward."

There was a slight contradiction in the Beast Miao King's words about there still being time. As long as Dark Heaven existed, no one knew what might happen.

Still, I was all for resting a while before we talked.

At least nothing unusual seems to have happened in Nanman yet.

I nodded, and the Beast Miao King looked toward Yayul Mok, standing at attention to his right.

"Mok."

One word was enough. Yayul Mok bowed respectfully, then gestured for us to follow him.

"We'll take our leave."

"Go. I'll prepare a grand welcome for you."

Forget the grand welcome. I just hope the talks about joining the alliance and Dark Heaven go well.

We turned away from the Beast Miao King. As we reached the doors, the slabs of carved stone began to move.

Rumble.

Through the slowly widening gap, I could see two muscular men in bear hides pulling chains attached to the doors.

And then…

“It’s been a long time.”

The man with the rigid voice was there too.

At his unexpected greeting, Yayul Mok bowed his head.

“Yayul Mok of the Miao people pays his respects to Uncle Baeksang.”

The middle-aged man of another ethnicity was dressed entirely in white, from head to toe, including his clothing and accessories. The man Yayul Mok had called Uncle Baeksang opened his mouth.

“I heard you’d returned. There was quite a large fire in the northeastern pasture, I hear.”

“It was a minor problem. We put it out quickly.”

“A minor problem.”

The cold gaze that accompanied his rigid voice swept over us. Baeksang examined Yayul Mok and everyone standing behind him.

Me in particular.

“I hope so.”

“…”

“And the Palace Lord?”

“He’s waiting inside.”

That was all. Baeksang glanced at Yayul Mok, who still had his head bowed, then passed us without another word.

Rumble.

The stone doors closed with another heavy grinding sound. Only then did Yayul Mok raise his head.

He stared at the shut doors, his lips pressed tight. I asked, “Who was that?”

“None of your business.”

“Don’t want to tell me, huh? Fine. Elder Namho?”

Namho, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion’s walking encyclopedia of Nanman, answered without hesitation.

“He’s the Great Chieftain of the Bai people, one of Nanman’s four most powerful tribes.”

“Oh. No wonder he’s dressed all in white. I saw a few Bai people near the entrance to Nanman. Those whiteys, right?”

Namho sounded taken aback. “Whiteys… Well, you’re not wrong. The tribe reveres the color white.”

More than thirty tribes lived throughout Nanman, each with its own villages and customs. Yeongin was something of a meeting place, where several tribes, including the Bai people, lived together by making compromises.

I didn't know they were that powerful.

The Great Chieftain of one of the four tribes that divided up this vast land…

I'd suspected he was important when Yayul Mok called him Uncle, but Baeksang was a bigger figure than I'd imagined.

Now that I had the basics, I caught up with Yayul Mok, who had gotten well ahead of us.

"You two didn't seem very close. Is he really your uncle?"

"…"

"Hey. Hey, can't you hear me?"

"…"

"If someone calls you, you're supposed to answer. Do you want to see the burning pasture? Huh? Want me to start a nice fucking fire on the way back?"

"…"

"Oh, this bastard is ignoring me to the very end. Fine, I get it. You have to see fire, not a coffin, before you'll cry."

As a trash talker, I had a hundred percent win rate. This time was no different.

"…Please stop spouting bullshit I can't understand."

"Oh, then behave yourself. If you answered promptly, none of this would happen."

Yayul Mok glared at me for a moment, then sighed.

"Think before you ask. Would we belong to different tribes if he were my uncle by blood?"

"Fair point. So why call him Uncle?"

"He and my father are sworn brothers. They became close when they were young, and I'm told they always fought together during the Great Faction War."

My eyes widened.

"What? Really?"

"I'd heard you Han Chinese bastards were suspicious, but I didn't expect it to be true. What, don't you believe me?"

"It's not that, but… I was a little surprised."

"Is it so surprising that they're sworn brothers?"

"No, not that."

"…?"

"Great Hero Yayul Cheok was your father? Not your grandfather or great-grandfather?"

"…!"

Yayul Mok's eyes went cold, but I couldn't help being surprised. The guy looked twenty-five at most, and he was the son of the Beast Miao King, who was well past eighty.

Martial artists tended to marry late, but this was impressive in a whole different way.

"Um, Pavilion Master?"

I waved off Ju Hwaran's cautious call.

"Just a second. One last question. You're not the eldest son, are you?"

Tap tap tap.

Yayul Mok suddenly walked faster. He forced the words through his teeth.

"I'm the only son in three generations."

"Wow. Yayul Only Son. Omniscient Nanman Reader's Viewpoint—totally doable."[2796]

"What does that mean? Are you actually insane?"

"I say things people can't understand sometimes. Anyway, that Baeksang fellow seems to be against the Nanman Beast Palace joining the alliance, right? Whatever happened back then, you two aren't on great terms now?"

"That's no concern of an outsider like you—!"

This was why the flow of a conversation mattered.

Yayul Mok had answered with his face flushed in anger, but he caught himself and trailed off. Too late. The water was spilled, and the fire had spread.

Having baited him perfectly, I smiled warmly and patted his shoulder.

"You bastard. Why'd you stop? My guess was right, then?"

"…You."

"That's enough for now. I'll ask again if I need to. Thanks. Oh, this is our lodging, right? Thanks for showing us the way."

I left Yayul Mok glaring at me like he wanted to kill me and turned around. Namho was staring at me like a caveman who had just discovered fire.

"Ever thought of joining the Hidden Shadow Pavilion?"

"The Hidden Shadow Pavilion? Forget it. Anyway, you heard all that, didn't you?"

"Of course. The way you lured him in and hooked him—you're at least as good as Jiang Taigong."[2797]

I answered solemnly.

"A fisherman who catches people. Please call me Jindro."

"Jindro…!"

[2796] In Korean, *dokja* can mean both "only son" and "reader." The line plays on the title *Omniscient Reader's Viewpoint*.

[2797] Jiang Taigong is a legendary Chinese fisherman associated with the image of drawing people in like fish.

Ju Hwaran and Hyuk Mujin clenched their fists, their faces alight with excitement.

"Pavilion Master, that was incredible. I really thought you'd lost your mind at first."

"Young Lady Ju is right. I was so frustrated that I wanted to tear Captain's mouth open and kill him."

That felt like a strange sort of praise, but I'd gotten the job done. I smiled with satisfaction.

"Thank you, Young Lady Ju. Mujin, head down."

"Yes, sir."

Thud.

Hyuk Mujin planted his head on the ground as naturally as breathing, and I sat on his back.

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo watched us in disbelief.

"That was absurd, but… we did learn something important."

"Pavilion Master, what do you intend to do now?"

I shrugged.

We had new information, but the Great Chieftain of the Bai people opposing the Nanman Beast Palace's entry into the Murim Alliance was hardly good news.

What bothered me more was *why*.

Why? Why?

Why would a man who had fought in the Great Faction War—the Beast Miao King's childhood friend and sworn younger brother—oppose joining the alliance?

And what had that coldness in Baeksang's eyes meant during our brief encounter? Why had he studied me so closely?

I couldn't stop thinking about it.

Grrrrrrk.

"Taishan. Hungry."

"…"

That fucking bastard.

The Beast Miao King sat in a high-backed chair draped with leopard and tiger hides, his chin propped on one hand. He picked up the wine bottle before him.

Trickle.

Cloudy liquor poured from the rough stone bottle he had carved himself, filling a large wooden bowl. He filled a second and offered one to his guest.

"It's the fruit wine you like. Have some, Baeksang."

Baeksang. The name meant *white elephant*.

But the middle-aged man who caught the slowly flying bowl looked nothing like one. He was lean, unlike the Beast Miao King, with eyes as cold as ice and a mouth held stiff. His answer was just as rigid.

"No, thank you. I'll pass today."

Clack.

Baeksang set the bowl down with a clack. The Beast Miao King smiled bitterly.

"…I see. That's fine."

It wasn't fine. His heart ached.

In memories grown hazy with time, his one sworn brother had laughed and talked with him for days and nights, their cups never still. For decades now, that brother had given him the same answer.

I'll pass today.

It wasn't only today. He had said it the day before yesterday and yesterday. Tomorrow and the day after would be the same.

The Beast Miao King knew the answer so well he could predict it. Knowing he would be right hurt all the more.

"So, what brings you to see your older brother today?"

Baeksang's voice did not waver.

"You know why."

"Because of them."

"I heard they came from the Murim Alliance."

"That's right. Sword Saint Mae Jonghak, the new Alliance Leader, sent them."

The Beast Miao King admitted it readily. There was no reason to hide it, and Baeksang would hear about it regardless. Plenty of Bai people belonged to the Nanman Beast Palace's Inner Hall.

He may even know exactly who they are.

The Baeksang he knew had always been meticulous. This time would be no different.

Baeksang's cold eyes settled on the Beast Miao King as he silently raised his bowl.

"You haven't forgotten the result of the last tribal council, have you?"

Of course not.

As the Beast Miao King answered inwardly, Baeksang's rigid voice pierced his ears.

"We—the Nanman Beast Palace… will never join the alliance."

Chapter 627

The temporary lodging we'd been assigned was decent enough. It wasn't as lavish as the accommodations in the Central Plains, but it was clean and had everything the Fire Dragon Pavilion and I needed for our stay.

That didn't mean we'd been welcomed without reservation.

"Hmm. Does anyone know what's stuck between my chopsticks?"

Hyuk Mujin shot his hand up at the surprise quiz I'd sprung on everyone in the middle of the meal.

"Okay, Mujin. Let's hear it."

"A bug!"

"Correct. A centipede, to be precise. So why is it in our food?"

"Hmm. Perhaps it's a custom of the non-Han people of Nanman?"

Namho, who had eighty years of experience being one of those people, picked out something that looked like a pine caterpillar and muttered, "First I've heard of it…"

I could have understood roasted locusts, more or less. But it looked as though someone had dumped live insects into the food. I couldn't defend that.

Sama Pyo sighed as he watched Taishan, who was still determined to bury his face in his plate.

"So we aren't welcome after all."

There was no way we could eat this. Song Ilseom set down his chopsticks and answered calmly.

"It's probably because of the Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau incident."

I agreed. But I didn't think Yayul Mok had personally ordered it. Someone who was Young Palace Lord wouldn't resort to anything this petty.

So this was the work of other non-Han people within the Nanman Beast Palace.

We'd been hated ever since we entered Nanman. Even the ugly duckling hadn't had it this bad, I thought, just as Ju Hwaran quietly appeared. She'd gone upstairs before the meal to wash up.

"Huh? You're done already?"

How long had she been up there? Not even Recruit Number 54 at the Nonsan training center could wash that fast.

She gave me an uneasy smile. "Ah, yes."

"…"

I had a bad feeling. I kept looking at her, and after a moment's hesitation, she spoke.

"Actually…"

By the time I'd heard the whole story, all I could do was laugh in disbelief.

"They gave you boiling-hot water in this weather? With something like filth mixed into it?"

Hwaran nodded, looking uncomfortable.

"I wasn't going to say anything. It could have been a mistake, and I didn't want it to cause trouble…"

"It wasn't a mistake. And don't worry about causing trouble. We've already got another problem."

Only then did she notice what had happened to our meal. She offered a brief assessment.

"Ugh."

"Just checking—you're not going to eat it, are you?"

"No. Of course not."

I'd never heard Hwaran answer so firmly. I clicked my tongue and stood.

"Captain, where are you going?"

"To make a scene."

Sit still and people take you for a sack; let them get away with enough and they'll take you for wrapping cloth. That was how the world worked.

We were here to persuade the Nanman Beast Palace, so I'd keep it within reason. But I had to raise hell at least once if I didn't want this to happen again.

I was about to fling open the door when I remembered something and stopped.

"Oh. One more thing."

"Yes?"

"Make him stop eating."

No one had to ask who I meant. Only one person was wolfing down his third bowl of colorful insect fried rice.

Sama Pyo looked at Taishan with sorrow in his eyes.

"Taishan. Stop…"

Yeah. Please stop.

It was the largest tree I'd ever seen.

Dozens of grown men would have needed to stretch their arms out to encircle its trunk. It towered at least several dozen jang[2798] above me.

The sight drew a silent gasp from me, but I hadn't come to admire the tree. I'd come to see someone.

"Hey. Get down."

Rustle.

[2798] A jang is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to ten cheok, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

The thick leaves shook. A beast growled low, and Yayul Mok's displeased voice came from above.

"You again. How did you find this place?"

"I asked. Someone told me you come here a lot."

"Who?"

"The guy who manages the pavilion."

"Hwang Gae?"

"Maybe it was Hwang Gae or Ddong Gae. Something like that."

"He's not the sort to tell a Han Chinese where I am."

"Maybe not a Han Chinese. He was pretty forthcoming with my fist."

"…"

"Come down. My neck hurts."

I doubted he'd come down just because my neck hurt, so I kindly added, "Before I break the tree."

"My ancestors' ancestors planted this tree. It took root here a thousand years ago."

"Then, sometime far in the future, your descendants will say, 'There used to be a thousand-year-old tree here, but some Han Chinese bastard came and ripped it out by the roots.' And when the child asks, 'Why, Mom?' she'll say, 'Because our ancestor wouldn't come down from the tree when asked nicely.'"

"…"

"So get down before I destroy the environment."

I wondered if I'd really have to pull it out if he refused again, but Yayul Mok loved nature more than I'd expected.

Rustle. Tap.

The White Tiger stepped from branch to branch and landed smoothly, letting out a low growl at me. Yayul Mok gave its neck a light stroke and glared.

"Madman."

"Come on. You're only noticing now?"

I scratched the back of my head bashfully. Yayul Mok's face reddened, and he snarled like a wild beast.

"What happened to Hwang Gae?"

"Oh, him? All four limbs are fine. He's a little scared, though."

"You're out of your mind. You come here asking for help, then bully the people of Nanman?"

"You've got the wrong idea. I didn't lay a finger on him. I did grab him by the collar, though."

I wasn't some neighborhood thug. I hadn't gone around acting like that even in the Central Plains. I always started by asking nicely and only used my fists when that didn't work. This time, I'd had plenty of reason.

"Insect fried rice. Bathwater mixed with filth."

"What?"

"If that isn't a traditional custom, then the Nanman Beast Palace's treatment of its guests is pretty terrible. Don't you think?"

Yayul Mok frowned. After a moment, he let out a sigh.

"I think I have a general idea of what happened."

"If you had a general idea, you should have warned them beforehand."

"I didn't think they'd show their hostility quite so openly…"

He stopped mid-sentence, then dipped his head toward me.

"I'm sorry. I sincerely apologize."

"…Oh."

"What's that reaction?"

"Nothing."

I was a little surprised. We hadn't known each other long, but Yayul Mok seemed too proud and rough-edged to bow his head so readily.

The type to admit when he's wrong and not hold a grudge?

It was easy to make a mistake, but hard to admit it and apologize sincerely.

In that sense, the young Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace had a better personality than I'd expected.

"I'll replace the people responsible as soon as I get back. Hwang Gae and everyone else involved. Nothing like this will happen again."

"Well, if you'll do that…"

"It was my mistake. Again, I apologize. I'd appreciate it if this didn't reach my father's ears."

"Why? Does he hit you when you do something wrong?"

Yayul Mok bristled. "What kind of nonsense is that?"

"If not, never mind. You went so far as to ask me not to tell him, so I thought you might get beaten for three days and three nights."

"My father has never laid a hand on me even once."

Well, if your father was the Beast Miao King, you'd probably grow up fine without him laying a hand on you. At that size and with that martial power, he could probably get his son, grandson, and maybe even his great-grandson through puberty without any trouble.

While I was thinking that, Yayul Mok hesitated, then added quietly, "I'll be fine. The others won't. If my father finds out, he'll come down on them like thunder."

"Ah."

"You're guests my father welcomed. You Han Chinese have every right to protest how you've been treated. But I don't want Hwang Gae or the others punished for it."

"Because they're pissed off about that fucking Dick Demon Escort Bureau?"

"…You've got the name a little wrong, but yes. That's one reason."

"One reason. Sounds like there's another."

Yayul Mok stared at me silently for a while. Then, as he stroked the chin of the now-quiet White Tiger, he opened his mouth.

"The Great Faction War."

"Hmm?"

"We shed far too much blood in the Central Plains. Under my father's leadership, all of Nanman's tribes joined forces, and as many as ten thousand warriors went to the battlefield. But the number of those who returned home alive was less than a quarter of that."

Grrr.

The White Tiger accepted his touch, then looked up at its master with worried eyes.

Yayul Mok went on, his voice heavy with conflicting emotions.

"Someone's parents. Someone's children. Friends and relatives who had grown up together since childhood. Most of them left for the battlefield with smiles on their faces and never returned. Even I, who was born long afterward, wasn't exempt."

"You did?"

"Under ordinary circumstances, I'd never have become Young Palace Lord. That's the real answer to the question you asked earlier."

I thought back to our conversation just after we'd left the Beast Miao King. Then I understood.

"You had older siblings."

"Three. One of them was my elder sister. She was young, and she was a woman, but I heard she was as brave as any warrior. If she hadn't participated in the Great Faction War, she would have married the man she loved. My father and Uncle Baeksang would have become in-laws as well as sworn brothers."

"Wait. Then…"

"What you're thinking is right. In the war between Han Chinese that they called the Great Faction War, my father lost two sons and a daughter. Uncle Baeksang lost the son he treasured more than his own life."

Yayul Mok smiled bitterly and added, "Don't blame Hwang Gae too much. He lost his parents and all his relatives."

I had nothing to say, so I simply closed my mouth.

I'd heard about the Great Faction War so many times my ears practically rang with it, but I hadn't known Nanman had suffered losses like these.

No. If I was honest, I hadn't thought I needed to know. Nanman was in the Outer Lands, tens of thousands of ri[2799] from the Central Plains. I'd thought of it as a separate land, far removed from Murim.

The others who still talked about the war probably thought the same way. Only Jeok Cheongang and a tiny handful of others had even mentioned that Nanman had suffered heavy losses.

So they must have all been carrying old resentment. The Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau incident from recently must have been the flashpoint.

Whatever Reward they'd received after the war, the wound was still there. It had only just begun to heal, barely forming a scab, when this happened.

"Only a few decades ago, we united and risked our lives fighting for the Han Chinese. And now, you killed some of us."

Yayul Mok's voice reached me, cold and seething.

[2799] A Korean ri is a traditional measure of distance equal to about 393 m or 0.244 mi.

Chapter 628

"Only a few decades ago, we stood together and risked our lives fighting for the Han Chinese. And now, you've turned your swords on us."

At that moment, Yayul Mok was genuinely furious.

More than two hundred people had been massacred in the recent tragedy. Most of the victims had been powerless old men, women, and children.

They were Miao people, just as he was. And after doing that to them, the Han Chinese still had the nerve to ask for help.

"We've already shed enough blood. Not for ourselves, but for you Han Chinese."

His voice trembled with anger.

"Nanman will not shed blood in vain again. Stop causing trouble and go home."

The words came out sharp and firm as a blade. Having finally said everything he'd been holding back, Yayul Mok felt a weight lift as he looked at the Han Chinese man before him.

Jin Taekyung, was it?

Half a day ago, Yayul Mok had known almost nothing about him. He'd heard in passing that Jin Taekyung was a renowned young prodigy from the Central Plains, but that was all.

If the absurd rumor that he was a Supreme Peak master was true, though, he might rank among the three greatest warriors even here in Nanman, where Yayul Mok had been born and raised.

He blocked Father's punch. Maybe the rumor is true.

Yayul Mok knew better than anyone how formidable his father, Yayul Cheok, was.

Before turning forty, his father had become Nanman's greatest warrior. He had made the Miao people its strongest tribe and, with the recognition of all, become lord of the Nanman Beast Palace.

Nor was that all. His martial power had won the admiration of even the Han Chinese of the Central Plains, who treated the people of Nanman as barbarians. Yayul Mok had heard that was when his father earned the name Beast Miao King.

I thought Uncle Baeksang was the only one who could exchange blows with Father.

Yet Jin Taekyung's martial arts were astonishing, especially for someone no older than Yayul Mok himself. He had blocked a punch from Yayul Cheok without much difficulty—a punch Yayul Mok could barely see, let alone stop.

True, its force had driven Jin Taekyung back nearly one jang.[2800] That was hardly a reason to underestimate him.

And besides…

[2800] A jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

He was big. A head or two taller than an ordinary grown man, with broad shoulders and a muscular build his clothes couldn't hide.

Facing him at close range now, Yayul Mok felt as though he were looking at a beast standing on two legs.

Maybe it was his size. Or maybe it was the way the eyes and mouth that always seemed to be smiling had gone still. Either way, Yayul Mok swallowed hard without meaning to.

Then Jin Taekyung spoke.

"Hey."

"…!"

"Why'd you jump? I just called you."

Yayul Mok flinched at the sudden low voice. "Wh-why did you call me?"

"Why are you stuttering?"

Because you're looking at me like that, you bastard.

Until now, Jin Taekyung had always seemed lighter than a feather. With the smile gone from his face, he felt more like a boulder weighing ten thousand geun.[2801]

—Grrr…

The white tiger beside Yayul Mok seemed to feel its master's unease. Pretending to be calm, Yayul Mok stroked his beloved tiger's neck as it shrank back beside him.

"I-I didn't stutter."

"…"

"Why did you call me? If you've got something to say, say it."

"Hmm. Nothing much."

Jin Taekyung gave him an odd look, scratched the back of his head, and said, "Thanks for telling me."

"Huh?"

"Thanks for being honest. There were things I didn't know, and you've cleared up quite a bit for me. I understand what's going on around here a little better, too."

What is he talking about?

This was nothing like the reaction Yayul Mok had expected. He stared at Jin Taekyung for a moment, then asked, "So you mean… you're going back?"

"Hm?"

Jin Taekyung tilted his head. "How did you get that from what I said?"

"No, but you said you understood."

"Yeah. Of course I understand. It's not like I'm incapable of empathy."

"Then?"

[2801] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

"That's a separate matter."

"What?"

"This'll take too long if I explain everything, and my mouth hurts. So let's cut to the chase and ask one thing."

Jin Taekyung leaned back against a tree and lowered his voice.

"Do you honestly think the Great Faction War was fought only for the Han Chinese?"

"…!"

"And since we're on the subject, do you think the Nanman people who died in that war died like dogs for no reason?"

"That's…"

"That's what?"

Yayul Mok found himself at a loss for words. For some reason, the answer wouldn't come. As he searched his muddled thoughts for one, Jin Taekyung's quiet voice reached him again.

"There are two reasons you can't answer. First, you know I'm right, but you don't want to admit it. And second…"

Jin Taekyung held up two fingers.

"Because you're still a brainless brat."

"What is that supposed to—"

"Don't ask me. Think about it yourself. Why did the Nanman Beast Palace take so many warriors tens of thousands of li[2802] to help the Central Plains? Just because an ancestor of the Fire Gate Clan brought order to Nanman ages ago? Even that white tiger beside you would laugh at that."

"…!"

"Most people in Nanman probably oppose joining the alliance for the first reason. They think all that blood was shed for nothing, and they don't want to repeat it."

Jin Taekyung went on with a sigh.

"If you look at it that way, it isn't entirely wrong. Who the fuck wants war? So what if you fight like hell and gain land, gold, and silver treasures? People are dying like ants in every direction. And some of those ants might be my friends, my family, or my lover. They could even be me—or you. By the way, do you have a girlfriend?"

Yayul Mok shook his head before he could think.

"An ex-girlfriend?"

"What exactly do you mean by 'girlfriend'?"

"A lover. A woman you date and have feelings for."

"Uh, no."

[2802] A Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi).

“Oh. So you had one?”

“No.”

“Right. So you *had* one?”

“…I’ve never had one. Not even once.”

“How old are you?”

“Twenty-six.”

“What a guy. A promising candidate for the virgin-boy technique. If you hold out like this for fifty years, you might even become a Martial God. Fine, let’s take lovers off the list of victims.”

Jin Taekyung smiled, looking pleased for some reason. Yayul Mok felt his mood sour as the tension went out of him.

The man was impossible to get a read on. So was this conversation.

“What the hell are you trying to say? Why did you suddenly go off on a tangent about lovers?”

“Who knows? I’m not entirely sure myself. But I do know one thing.”

The faint smile left Jin Taekyung’s face.

“The people of Nanman who left home and died in the Central Plains all those years ago did not die for nothing. And if the same thing happens again, their deaths won’t be for nothing this time, either.”

“…”

“I’m sincerely sorry about what happened with the Heavenly Demon Escort Bureau. But if there were people crazy enough to do something like that… I would have killed them myself.”

“Even though they were Han Chinese, like you?”

“What does that have to do with it?”

Was it his imagination, or had Jin Taekyung left him speechless several times today?

Yayul Mok pressed his lips together and stared at him before saying, “No matter how good your words sound, Nanman won’t help the Central Plains.”

“It’ll be hard to convince you. I still have to try.”

“It’s pointless.”

“What?”

“It’s as good as decided. The first tribal council reached a conclusion fifteen days ago.”

“*First*? Sounds like there’s going to be a second.”

“Nanman is vast. Gathering all thirty-two tribes in one place takes time, so the four great chieftains, including my father, consider matters first.”

“And they decided against joining the alliance? Go on.”

"In three days, every tribe in Nanman will gather for a council. But the other great chieftains have already made up their minds. I doubt anything will change."

Yayul Mok was telling the truth. The Nanman Beast Palace was a symbol of unity, but that didn't make the tribes equal.

If the three great chieftains led by Baeksang, the Great Chieftain of the Bai people, stood together, even the Beast Miao King—Nanman's greatest warrior and lord of the palace—could not decide on his own to join the alliance.

Those are the rules here.

Yayul Mok watched Jin Taekyung closely. How would this young, powerful Han Chinese from the Central Plains react now that Nanman's joining the alliance was all but impossible?

He'll probably be disappointed. If not, he'll surely exhaust himself trying to persuade us somehow…

"I'll do what I can. If it doesn't work, it doesn't work."

"Huh?"

Yayul Mok couldn't hide his surprise. Jin Taekyung sounded far calmer than he'd expected.

"B-but the result is already decided, isn't it?"

"Yeah. You also said it isn't over yet."

"That's true, but…"

What is with him?

Yayul Mok frowned. "Don't you have to persuade us somehow?"

"That's what I said I'd try to do. If I can't, I'll go home. After I deal with something more important, of course."

"More important?"

"You've got the wrong idea."

Jin Taekyung scratched his chin.

"I didn't come here as a diplomat. I'm more like a firefighter."

"A firefighter? What's that?"

"Someone who puts out fires."

"Didn't you set fire to the pasture as soon as you arrived?"

Jin Taekyung fell silent at the earnest question.

"…It's a metaphor. What I mean is, persuading people isn't exactly my greatest talent."

"That seems true."

"…You fucking bastard. Now I'm getting annoyed for no reason. Anyway, it'd be a shame if Nanman didn't join us, but if trying doesn't work, there's nothing we can do."

"But you're Han Chinese. And you belong to the Murim Alliance."

“So?”

“I don’t know the exact circumstances, but I know well enough that the Central Plains is in danger. At a time like this, when you should be begging us for help no matter what, you came to help us?”

Jin Taekyung let out a quiet laugh at the way Yayul Mok looked at him, as though he were some strange creature.

“What would you do if the pasture caught fire again?”

“Put it out at once.”

“Why?”

“If we don’t put it out, the flames will spread in every direction.”

“Good. There’s your answer.”

“…!”

“Don’t make it complicated. There’s a fire, so I’m trying to put it out. Just like the people of Nanman who left this land for the Central Plains decades ago.”

Yayul Mok was silent for a moment. Then, with a troubled look, he asked, “So you came here just to help us… without expecting anything in return?”

“What if I did?”

“I don’t believe you.”

“Believe what you want. But before any of that…”

Jin Taekyung naturally turned around and began walking. Then he continued with a suddenly hardened expression.

“At least feed me properly, asshole.”

Chapter 629

After parting ways with Yayul Mok, I headed back toward the temporary lodging where the Fire Dragon Pavilion members were waiting.

With my martial prowess, I wasn't in danger of anyone trying to harm me. Still, wandering around alone in this atmosphere wouldn't do me any good.

Somehow, I found myself in the Nanman Beast Palace's Outer Hall.

"Huh. When did I get here?"

I muttered to myself and looked around.

Perhaps because it was hidden among the thick, overgrown grass, I couldn't see a single rat anywhere…

Well, not quite. Two or three monkeys were milling around—Nanman's mascots, much like Gukkeoni was for the Ministry of National Defense.

—Screech?

Why's that Han Chinese bastard crawling around out here instead of staying put in his lodging?

That seemed to be the question in the monkey's curious eyes. But I had nothing to be ashamed of before the heavens.

I got lost. What do you want me to do about it?

Of course, I'd followed the advice of the greatest assassin of all time disguised as the Divine Physician: conceal my breathing and move stealthily so no one would spot me.

But one thing was certain. I was lost.

The lodging was less than fifteen minutes away, and there were only two roads, but that was beside the point. If I said I was lost, I was lost.

Still, I'm here representing the Murim Alliance. I should be able to figure out this much on my own.

Back at the Hunter Training Center, a fellow recruit had once said that a perfect lie was a true story.

In the end, all that mattered was not getting caught. Though in this atmosphere, I did need to make an effort to avoid it.

Rustle.

I steadied my breathing, slipped out of the grass, and blended into the people gathered nearby.

I suppressed my presence, reined in my aura, and bent slightly at the waist to make myself look shorter. Just as Mungyeong had taught me.

Do you know who the most frightening assassin in the world is?

Sure. The person standing right in front of me.

…

I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. I've committed a crime worthy of death. Please put the dagger in your sleeve away and teach this fool.

Mungyeong had glared at me as though deciding whether to kill me, then answered.

An ordinary person.

Ordinary?

Someone more ordinary than anyone else, who blends naturally into any place. That is the most frightening assassin.

What Mungyeong taught me that day wasn't useful only to assassins.

He'd mentioned it in passing, calling it a simple trick that couldn't even be considered martial arts. But I hadn't forgotten it, and it had come in handy more than once.

Just like now.

This really is different from the Central Plains.

I turned my head without drawing attention and looked around the Outer Hall.

Even on a second look, the Nanman Beast Palace was a distinctive place. It was less like a sect than a small city, with all kinds of peoples living together.

Compared to the Central Plains, where the Han Chinese made up the majority, Nanman was practically a melting pot of races.

A Miao woman draped in colorful jewelry strode through the market, enjoying the attention of the people around her, while a Bai merchant in white traditional clothing tried to conduct a trade with a monkey perched on his shoulder.

And an old man was limping straight toward me.

No, sir. Why are you coming this way?

"Excuse me. I'm trying to buy some cloth at the market. Which shop would you recommend? If I were ten years younger, I could have found it with my eyes closed, but perhaps it's because I'm old that I can't remember anything these days."

"Uh…"

Had I blended in too well? I hadn't expected this.

The non-Han old man had blocked my path with his cane and asked me the question. I hesitated for a moment, then answered as shamelessly as possible.

"Go straight ahead, then take the alley on the right."

"The alley on the right? Was there a cloth shop there?"

How would I know, sir?

But contrary to my thoughts, I nodded.

"Yes. Plenty of them. More than the hairs on your head. They're springing up everywhere."

"Really? What's one of them called?"

Why do you need the name, too?

Hesitating now would make him suspicious, so I blurted out the first name that came to mind.

“Hyuk Family Textile Shop. Their cloth is pretty good.”

“Hyuk Family Textile Shop? I don’t think I’ve heard of it…”

I’d underestimated how well a local knew his own market.

It was clearly an unreasonable answer, but in situations like this, the shameless person won. With an expression utterly free of shame, I spoke firmly.

“It’s been there for over ten years.”

“Really? That’s strange. I could’ve sworn…”

“Isn’t your memory getting hazy? That’s why you asked me, right?”

“Well, yes, but…”

“Sir, if you don’t mind my asking, how old are you?”

“Me? Eighty-two.”

“I’m twenty-two. I can still vividly remember moving from my father’s side to my mother’s.”

“You remember *that*?”

“I’m only twenty-two, so I remember everything. Trust me.”

“Ah. All right, then. Thank you.”

Defeated by sheer force of confidence, the old man turned to leave. I suddenly remembered something and called after him.

“Sir?”

“Hmm? What is it?”

“Where is the place with the biggest crowd right now? I was supposed to meet someone, but that bastard isn’t showing up anywhere, so I’m going to look for him myself.”

“Try over there.” He pointed with his cane. “I caught a glimpse of it on my way here. No idea what’s going on, but it was awfully noisy. Probably something to do with the festival in a few days.”

Then he paused and studied my face with his cloudy eyes.

“By the way, which tribe are you from?”

“What?”

“You don’t look Yao, like me. Yet you speak our language so well. How strange…”

“Oh, I can see it over there. Please be careful on your way.”

“Hey. Wait.”

I left the old man behind and walked away quickly.

No matter how naturally I blended in, anyone who had enough time to study my face would notice. The differences between the Han Chinese and Nanman's other peoples weren't so pronounced that I'd stand out at a glance, but they were there.

Fortunately, there was a solution.

My hands were very fast. And as luck would have it, the market was packed with non-Han people, while the merchant selling traditional animal masks was too busy dealing with customers pouring in from every direction to pay attention to anything else.

In short, slipping one mask away was no trouble at all.

Open Inventory. Store.

Ding.

The hand wasn't faster than the eye. The System was.

I put the mask in my Inventory. By the time I'd passed a couple of people, the tiger mask, painted with crude dye, was on my face.

This should do. It won't stand out around here.

Maybe it was because of the festival the old man had mentioned. Two or three out of every ten people I saw were wearing similar masks.

I headed in the direction he'd pointed and listened to the voices around me.

"Did you hear? The great chieftains of the Yi and Yao peoples are back."

"Really? I heard they went to subdue man-eating beasts about fifteen days ago."

"They mobilized around five hundred warriors, so they must have finished quickly. Unlike the Yao people, it seems the great chieftain of the Yi people didn't achieve any noteworthy results, though."

"Just what I expected. Not that I expected much."

I didn't miss the familiar information exchanged in their conversation.

The Yi and Yao peoples.

Together with the Miao and Bai peoples—led respectively by the Beast Miao King, lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, and Baeksang, whom I had briefly encountered earlier—the Yi and Yao peoples made up Nanman's four most powerful tribes.

I remembered what Namho had told me on our way to the Nanman Beast Palace.

Nanman's four great tribes are the Miao, Bai, Yi, and Yao peoples. The Miao are the strongest, followed by the Bai.

What about the Yi and Yao?

Twenty or thirty years ago, the Yi would have been ahead.

Sounds like they aren't anymore.

Times have changed. Many say the Yi great chieftain, who inherited the position from his late father, lacks resolve. The Yao, on the other hand, have grown considerably. They gained an exceptional leader. I doubt any man they put in her place could have done as much.

Wait. Are you saying…?

You've guessed right. The Yao great chieftain is a woman. Extremely intelligent, and extraordinarily beautiful.

My thoughts broke off. Not because I chose to stop thinking, but because a clear note from a distant instrument reached my ears.

Fwoooosh.

A gentle melody rode Nanman's hot, humid wind across the open space.

The noisy market fell silent in an instant, and a short exclamation escaped someone's lips.

"Ah…"

It was impossible to hold back. The melody was that pure, and the procession revealed as people hurriedly stepped aside was splendid and beautiful.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

Hundreds of men and women marched to the low beat of drums.

The Yi men wore black tops trimmed with floral cloth and wide, pleated trousers. The Yao women, in conical hats, walked slowly in two lines.

"Wow."

"The Yi and Yao have arrived!"

Cheers rose all around me.

But while everyone else admired their beauty and finery, I watched the weapons strapped to their waists and shoulders.

Every one of them is a warrior.

A warrior of Nanman was equivalent to a Murim practitioner in the Central Plains. Since these people belonged to their respective tribes, it would be more accurate to call them members of a martial sect.

And if the Yi and Yao great chieftains are back from subduing those beasts…

This was more than a procession. It was a victory parade, and a victory parade needed the generals who had led the battle.

In this case, those generals were the two great chieftains.

"Oh!"

"Th-there…!"

Cries rang out almost as soon as the thought occurred to me. Gazes and voices turned in one direction, and then the whole crowd erupted into cheers.

"Waaaaah!"

Amid the roar that seemed capable of shaking all of Nanman beyond the Outer Hall, two people finally appeared at the center of the procession and waved their hands.

A man riding an enormous black bear—presumably the Yi great chieftain. And…

“Yohi! Great Chieftain Yohi!”

A woman smiling brightly as the crowd lavished her with far more attention and affection than they had the man.

Even without hearing them call her name, I would have known she was the Yao great chieftain.

The Yao great chieftain is a woman. Extremely intelligent, and extraordinarily beautiful.

Namho had been right. Yohi was beautiful—almost bewitchingly so.

Whenever her deep gaze swept over the crowd, people gasped in admiration.

That was probably why I stood out. Amid all those cheers and admiring faces, I was standing there like a block of wood.

“…!”

Yohi’s eyes lit up when she spotted me.

Chapter 630

I'd let my guard down the moment I covered my face with the mask. That was my mistake.

Should I have stamped my feet and clapped like everyone else?

The thought came too late. Yohi was still looking straight at me.

Still, it shouldn't be a problem. All I'd done was stand there awkwardly without joining in.

The chances of the Yao people's great chieftain—the star of this splendid victory parade—showing any further interest in me were close to zero.

"You there."

"…"

I said *close* to zero. Not zero.

Damn it. She really is calling me.

Yohi was looking straight at me, so I cautiously turned around, just in case.

"Yes. You who just turned around."

Fortunately, I wasn't the only one who had turned. Yohi's sudden call had the whole marketplace murmuring and swiveling their heads like meerkats.

"The person in the tiger mask."

I swept my eyes over the crowd. There were a dozen or so people in cool-looking tiger masks, including me. Those were reassuring odds.

Good thing I'd bought a tiger mask. Not that I'd paid for it.

"The man standing seven cheok[2803] tall, wearing a tiger mask, who just made eye contact with me. That's enough. Come forward."

The tiger-mask stock crashed as soon as she added gender and height to the description. My odds of winning had shot up so fast I could feel sweat gathering on my forehead.

I ducked my head to avoid Yohi's gaze and swiftly, discreetly crossed my legs. Then I tucked my Black Anaconda neatly between them and looked up.

Yohi's gaze had gone flat.

"…"

"…"

The procession had stopped. The cheers were gone.

In the suffocating silence, with Yohi and countless others staring at me, I straightened my tightly pressed legs and spoke with all the gravity I could muster.

"Um. Did you call me?"

[2803] A *cheok* is a traditional Korean unit of length, about 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Seven cheok is about 2.12 m (6 ft 11 in).

"…"

"…"

No one answered. They just looked from my masked face to my lower body and back again.

Shit. I should've just stepped forward when she first called me.

A leader needed many qualities. A keen eye was one of them.

"I had a strange feeling the moment I saw you."

Once the procession celebrating the beast subjugation had ended, Yohi had sent an attendant to summon me privately. Now she went on in a languid voice.

"What should I call it? Out of all those people, you were the only one who seemed out of place."

Beside her, the great chieftain of the Yi people, who had been popping fruit into his mouth nonstop, grinned broadly and chimed in.

"She's right. Standing there like a block of wood all by yourself, you were hard to miss."

He was a plump, middle-aged man who hardly looked like a warrior. He waved a hand wet with fruit juice in greeting.

"And you're still wearing that mask. Rude fellow. I don't know who you are, but I expect you already know me. I'm Heugung, leader of the Yi people."

Heugung. The name meant Black Bear.

That explained the bear he'd ridden in the procession. Apparently, keeping a pet beast named after yourself was the thing to do around here.

What am I supposed to say?

Now that it had come to this, I'd planned to remove my mask and reveal who I was. That was why I hadn't slipped away earlier. But Yohi was far more perceptive than I'd expected.

"You can leave it on, Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Hmm?"

"What?"

I was surprised twice over: first that Yohi, who had only just arrived, knew exactly who I was, and then that Heugung, a fellow great chieftain, was even more shocked than I was.

At the sight of Heugung and me both freezing for a moment, Yohi let out a quiet laugh.

"Why are you so surprised? I already heard the Palace Lord let a group of Han Chinese from the Murim Alliance into the Inner Palace."

Heugung tilted his head.

"Han Chinese from the Murim Alliance? Really? I hadn't heard."

"That's because you're a foolish bear. Of course, I find that charming about you."

Even the Skeleton King could have spotted the lip service in that last remark. Heugung grinned happily.

"Do you mean that?"

"Of course. Don't forget that I've always been in love with you."

Her voice and gaze were alluring. Her pale, flawless fingers—so white and unblemished it was hard to believe she was from Nanman—stroked his pockmarked cheek. Bliss spread across Heugung's face.

"Ahh. My dear."

If someone asked me to describe the sight in three words, I'd have an answer ready.

Ugh. Fucking hell…

A potbellied man in his fifties was melting like butter under the touch of a beautiful woman in her twenties.

People said love knew no age or borders. Watching this, I thought we ought to invent some.

Not that this was real love.

Now I could see why the Yi people's power was falling like a stock headed for delisting—and how the Yao people had grown so strong.

Still… they're different, but there's a resemblance.

I was thinking of someone in particular when Yohi glanced at me and stroked Heugung's shoulder.

"But, oppa[2804]…"

"O-oppa[2805]?"

I'd heard that line a few times in the daily dramas my mother liked to watch.

Don't call me Manager. Call me Oppa[2806].

Yohi knew exactly what a troublesome middle-aged man wanted to hear. As Heugung looked ready to die of happiness, she continued gently.

"Would you step outside for a moment? There's something important I want to ask this Han Chinese man."

"Hmm? Of course. Of course I will! Anything you want!"

"Thank you, oppa[2807]. I'll see you later."

[2804] *Oppa* is a Korean form of address a woman uses for an older brother or older man; it can also carry flirtatious overtones.

[2805] *Oppa* is a Korean form of address a woman uses for an older brother or older man; it can also carry flirtatious overtones.

[2806] *Oppa* is a Korean form of address a woman uses for an older brother or older man; it can also carry flirtatious overtones.

[2807] *Oppa* is a Korean form of address a woman uses for an older brother or older man; it can also carry flirtatious overtones.

“Ooh. Oooooh!”

Heugung left the tent red-faced and snorting with excitement. Yohi gave a quiet laugh, leaned back against the silk bedding, and muttered, “Moron.”

I’d expected something like that, but not quite this much. I scratched my chin, and she lifted one corner of her mouth.

“What? Too obvious?”

When someone was this direct, it made things easier. After a moment’s thought, I answered honestly.

“Well, you’re not wrong.”

“You don’t seem surprised. I suppose you’d already figured it out. I thought you were only good at martial arts, but you’re quicker to catch on than I expected.”

“People like you are rare, but not unheard of. Murim has plenty who aren’t the same inside as they appear on the outside.”

“Really? I suppose the Central Plains must be very large. A bitch like me is rare in Nanman. Oh, is that girl who came with you the same sort? I think I heard her name was… Ju Hwaran?”

I stared at Yohi instead of answering. Her smile deepened.

“All right. I take it back. From your expression, I’d say I shouldn’t have said that.”

I didn’t know what expression I’d made. Probably not a friendly one. I could just feel it.

An odd feeling stirred in me. I made myself speak evenly.

“Watch what you say next time. She’s a member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion who trusted me enough to follow me all the way to Nanman.”

“Oh? Just a subordinate you care about?”

“I don’t really divide people into superiors and subordinates… but think what you want.”

“I appreciate you putting it that way. I happen to have quite a vivid imagination.”

Yohi let out an enigmatic laugh, apparently imagining something, then continued.

“You were staring at me earlier, so I got the wrong idea. I thought you might have fallen for me at first sight.”

“As if. I don’t go falling for just anyone.”

“Then why were you looking at me like that? Did Heugung, that fucking moron, look pathetic to you?”

“No. You reminded me of someone I’d seen before.”

Interest lit her eyes.

“Who? A woman?”

“A woman, yes. You wouldn’t know her even if I told you.”

In truth, she was closer to a monster than a woman. The person Yohi had reminded me of was the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

The people of Dark Heaven were monsters for whom distinctions between men and women meant nothing. Fanatics who worshipped the Lord of Heaven.

"Hmm. A woman… Do we look that much alike?"

"A little. But you're fundamentally different."

"How can you be sure? I could be her."

She looked mischievous, but I'd already checked with Qi Sense just in case. There was no mistaking one for the other.

Like I said, the two of them were fundamentally different.

Yohi's looks and manner were bewitching. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress possessed a magical power that could beguile people—and I didn't just mean her looks.

It was the way she carried herself.

There was something distinctive about her: beautiful, yet so natural you never thought to question it. Even I hadn't sensed the danger in her beauty or her manner until after she'd fooled me completely in Hubei Province.

"Either way, you're different."

"Hmm. That's no fun. Whoever she is, she must be important."

"She is. And even more dangerous."

"Dark Heaven. It's Dark Heaven, isn't it?"

Yohi was quick. She already knew why I'd come tens of thousands of li[2808] from the Central Plains to Nanman, and what I was here to do.

"I'm sorry to tell you, but none of the four great chieftains want to join the alliance. No one except the Palace Lord."

"What about you?"

"Me? I don't care either way. Whatever losses the Nanman Beast Palace suffers, I want the Yao people to bring the four great tribes under us."

"That's what *you* want. The other tribal chiefs…"

"Some of them want something else, of course. But most want their own tribes to grow stronger. On that much, I'm certain. If their people shed blood for nothing in the Central Plains, their power here in Nanman will naturally shrink."

I remembered what the Beast Miao King had told me in the Inner Palace. He was the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, and one of the Ten Kings recognized even in the Central Plains. In the end, though, he was also the Miao great chieftain.

If the chiefs who held sway over Nanman's many parts thought like Yohi, then Yayul Mok was right. The Nanman Beast Palace joining the Murim Alliance was all but impossible.

Fuck, these negotiations are a nightmare.

[2808] A Chinese *li* is a unit of distance equal to about 500 m (0.311 mi).

I hadn’t come to Nanman as a diplomat, but this situation was still as good as a failure before it had even begun.

Yohi looked amused by my reaction.

“I’m sorry, but that’s reality. Ah, of course, there’s at least one person you might have a chance of persuading. He leads a tribe large enough to rank among the four great tribes, and he’s so stupid that it’s hard to believe.”

I knew who she meant. I let out a sigh.

“Heugung?”

Yohi burst out laughing.

“Yes, that fucking moron. He can’t do a thing with me and that old man Baeksang keeping him firmly under our thumbs anyway.”

“…”

He was still the great chieftain of a huge tribe that raised plenty of bears. Did she really have to treat him like that? Just thinking about him made my heart sink.

And if I actually had a chance of persuading him, she wouldn’t be telling me so helpfully.

Heugung was a puppet, grinning away without realizing Baeksang and Yohi were pulling his strings.

Is she messing with me?

I frowned at Yohi. Outside the tent, people began moving about, and a voice reached us.

“Yohi. Are you in there?”

Cold and dry. It was Baeksang.

Chapter 631

Sometimes you can tell just by meeting someone's eyes that they dislike you. That no matter how hard you try, you'll never get along.

My second meeting with Baeksang, great chieftain of the Bai people, felt like that.

"You…"

Baeksang recognized me at once, even though my face was hidden behind a mask. Given his martial prowess, that wasn't surprising.

At least early Supreme Peak.

That was my estimate. A Supreme Peak master was hard to find even in the Central Plains. It would have been stranger if a crude tiger mask had fooled him. Once martial artists reached a certain realm, they could recognize someone by their bearing.

The important part wasn't that Baeksang knew who I was. It was that he wasn't the least bit pleased to see me.

"So we have an unwelcome guest."

Unwelcome, was it? If he'd said that when we first met, he might have scratched my tender heart. After everything I'd heard about him, though, I took it fairly calmly.

I scratched the back of my head. "They say you should speak straight even if your mouth is crooked. So, to set the facts straight, I'm not an unwelcome guest. I was invited."

"Invited?"

His gaze shifted to Yohi. She met his eyes with a sweet smile.

"It's true. I invited him."

A beautiful woman's smile worked wonders in most situations. Baeksang, apparently, wasn't most people.

"Do you intend to collude with the Han Chinese?"

His voice had grown colder. Yohi shrugged theatrically.

"Collude? I was only a little curious. It's not as if we were alone from the start."

"But only you two and the heavens know what you discussed after sending Heugung away."

"Set your worries aside. I haven't forgotten the promise we made that day."

I had no idea what they'd promised each other, but it sounded suspicious enough. Baeksang's gaze darkened.

"You're saying pointless things in front of a Han Chinese man, Yohi."

Fwoosh!

An invisible wave of qi rolled off Baeksang and swept through the tent.

The air grew heavy. Pressure from a Supreme Peak master bore down from every direction, and for the first time, Yohi's smile began to fade.

That was when I spoke up.

"Hey, the Han Chinese bastard is standing right here and can hear you. How about we stop with the 'bastard'?"

Whoosh.

The pressure building around us suddenly broke. Baeksang's eyebrows twitched as my words scattered the waves of qi.

"You bastard."

"Young Hero Jin. Pavilion Head Jin. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. Or just 'you.' Pick whichever one you like. At this point, I can't tell whether I'm from the Jin Family of Taiyuan or the Bastard Family of Taiyuan."

"…!"

"Good with words, aren't I? I know. But I trust you realize I didn't become a Murim Alliance Pavilion Head by running my mouth. Otherwise, my sobriquet wouldn't be Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. It'd be something like Wind Style: Mouth Dragon."

That should have made two things clear to Baeksang. First, my martial prowess was in no way beneath his. Second, I wasn't merely some young Han Chinese. I held a senior position in the Murim Alliance, formed from the martial world of the Central Plains.

Either one was enough to make me someone he couldn't simply dismiss.

Baeksang studied me in silence for a while.

"Now that I've had another look, you're certainly the successor to the Fire Gate Clan. Speaking and acting without a thought for the consequences… You truly are the Fire King's disciple."

"Old Master—no. Have you met my master?"

"The Palace Lord and I were always together. Including the day we first met the Fire King, whom we'd only heard of until then."

I had a sudden hunch. "Oh. Then were you…?"

"The Palace Lord went down before we could do a thing. I was next. I'd called him a crazy old man, you see."

Baeksang lifted his white robe slightly, revealing a burn scar on his side.

"…"

What was he, a cut of beef with a grade stamped on it?

That's practically a certification mark.

After showing me the mark left by the piping-hot Fire King hand pie he'd received decades ago, Baeksang continued coldly.

"It was a long time ago. But every time I see this scar, I remember it."

Jeok Cheongang had once warned me to be careful of gratitude and grudges in Murim. Now the ones he'd incurred in the past were coming back to me like a boomerang.

Is this Murim-style gratitude-and-grudges payback?

For a moment, I had nothing to say. Baeksang stared at me, his gaze dark and steady.

"I don't care whether you're the Fire King's disciple or a Murim Alliance Pavilion Head. Nanman has already shed enough blood for the Central Plains, and the Palace Lord's judgment is wrong."

"…"

"That is all I have to say. Get out of my sight before I deal with you myself."

Baeksang's manner was downright threatening. Rather than argue, I got to my feet.

Not because I was afraid of him, but because there was more to lose than to gain. This was a time to think calmly.

Step.

I was about to leave the tent when I stopped. There was something I wanted to tell Baeksang, and I didn't know when I'd see him again.

"That blood wasn't shed for the Central Plains."

"What?"

"The blood your people shed wasn't for the Central Plains. It was for the whole world."

I added quietly, "The same goes for someone's son."

Whoosh!

A fierce wave of qi erupted into a gale. Yohi, who had watched our exchange without a word, went pale. The huge tent swayed like a leaf caught in a typhoon.

At the center of it all stood Baeksang, trembling with rage.

"You…!"

Fire blazed in his eyes. His voice seemed to boil. I held his gaze.

Faced with all that fury, I found myself remembering someone who had been buried deep in my memory.

This…

I didn't know whether this suspicion was true or whether it would end as nothing more than a guess.

But before that, I had to show the proper respect for the reverse scale I had touched.[2809]

[2809] The Korean expression invokes a dragon's "reverse scale," a spot that must not be touched because doing so provokes its rage.

I bowed my head slightly to Baeksang and left the tent. All the way back to my quarters, I thought about a man who was unmistakably different from Baeksang, yet somehow resembled him.

…The Head Elder.

The Blade of Flowers, Jin Baekyang.

A hero of the Great Faction War born in Shanxi Province. A man who had nearly become Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan despite being the second son.

And a traitor who had spent decades under Dark Heaven's shadow.

I didn't know why he'd come to mind at that particular moment.

But perhaps… perhaps…

Damn it. I don't know.

I let out a long sigh. Ahead, outside the quarters we'd been temporarily assigned in the Inner Palace, Hyuk Mujin was roasting a whole wild boar. I had no idea where he'd gotten it.

Look at him. What a thoughtful little punk.

I gave him a hard time whenever I got the chance, but we'd been through thick and thin together since our days with the Jin Family of Taiyuan. And as a former gate guard, he knew more about the Head Elder than anyone else in the Fire Dragon Pavilion traveling with me.

Maybe he can offer some decent advice.

Just as I was about to wave at him happily, Hyuk Mujin spotted me approaching and abruptly raised one hand, holding a red-hot iron skewer.

"Who goes there?"

"…"

Advice, my ass.

I took off the tiger mask. "Put your head to the ground."

"Oh. Ha ha. I was joking."

"Good. I'm not. Put your head to the ground."

"…"

Clank.

The skewer slipped from Mujin's limp hand.

Two days passed in the blink of an eye.

Despite telling us at our first meeting to wait because he would summon us soon, the Beast Miao King hadn't sent for us once. Yayul Mok, on the other hand, had been visiting more often than I'd expected.

Thump.

White Tiger dropped the wild boar from his jaws and puffed out his chest proudly. I looked at Yayul Mok, who was stroking the tiger's neck.

"Where'd you catch this one?"

"In the western grass."

He answered without thinking, then hurried to correct himself.

"…I mean, I found it on the way here."

"Why bring something you found here?"

"Hmm. It seemed a shame to throw it away?"

"Funny. For something you found, those bite marks on its neck look exactly like a tiger's."

"My boy is well trained. He doesn't bite just anything, beast or human."

"…"

What kind of bullshit was that?

Was this one of those ideas that there were no bad tigers in the world?

I studied White Tiger's teeth, caked with blood and bits of flesh. "Looks like he'd chew up a beast or a person in one bite. You mean he's not a picky eater?"

"Anyway, he didn't do it. Must've been another tiger."

"Then why's there only one set of bite marks?"

"How should I know? I found it dead by the road and brought it here."

"Ah, right. A big, healthy wild boar died of natural causes by the road, and White Tiger just went *chomp* to carry it here?"

"Exactly."

"…"

There came a point when someone was so shameless I didn't have the energy to answer. I stared at Yayul Mok, then sighed at the mountain-sized boar.

"Another wild boar, though?"

"It's a wild boar. Is that a problem?"

"The boar again?"

"…Do Han Chinese have no conscience? Think of the trouble I went to catching it and bringing it here. Shut up and eat."

"Thought you found it."

"Ah. I misspoke. I found it."

This bastard was something else.

I only found out later that the meat Mujin had been roasting two days earlier had also come from Yayul Mok. No one had seen him bring it, of course, and he'd stubbornly denied being the one who had.

"Wild boar's fine for a day or two, but it's been days of nothing else. I'm sick of it. Sick of it."

"Then I'll take it back."

"Mujin. Get the meat."

"Yes, sir."

Yayul Mok and White Tiger gave me identical flat looks. I'd been thick-skinned too long for that to bother me.

Yayul Mok clicked his tongue as Mujin bustled about getting ready to cook, then turned back to me.

"How is your work going?"

I shook my head.

"So you haven't found anything."

"Not yet."

It wasn't as though I had spent the past two days doing nothing. The Fire Dragon Pavilion members and I had been investigating both inside and outside the Nanman Beast Palace.

I had Ju Hwaran and Hyuk Mujin investigate what was happening in the Inner Palace, while I led the remaining members in scouting the surrounding area.

We might find traces of Dark Heaven.

But despite our efforts, we had nothing to show for it. If there were no traces of Dark Heaven near the Nanman Beast Palace, that was good news. If we simply hadn't found them, it was another matter.

"For now, we'll keep looking. At least until the Tribal Grand Council."

The council, which would bring together all of Nanman's tribes, was tomorrow. Yayul Mok nodded, then lowered his voice.

"You'd better put it off today."

"Put it off? Why?"

"The Inner Palace has summoned you."

Chapter 632

The Inner Palace.

Our quarters were technically part of the Inner Palace too, but I knew at once that wasn't what Yayul Mok meant.

"Great Hero Yayul is summoning us?"

"Yes. To be precise, he told me to bring only you and that old man."

Good news. After all this time without a word, the Beast Miao King had finally agreed to my request for a private audience.

But why call for Namho and me alone, rather than the whole Fire Dragon Pavilion?

A thought struck me.

"Do we need to keep out of sight?"

Yayul Mok stared at me in surprise, then gave a small nod.

"You're quicker on the uptake than I expected. Try not to draw attention on the way."

"Because the Tribal Grand Council is tomorrow?"

"No. Because most of the tribal chiefs hate you people."

"…"

"It's true."

Was he a guillotine in a past life? He'd cut me off before I even got the words out.

I couldn't deny it, though. I smacked my lips bitterly.

"I get the picture. Great Hero Yayul's getting pressure from all sides, isn't he?"

Yayul Mok's lips moved as if he meant to answer, but his expression hardened and he closed his mouth.

Just as I couldn't deny what he'd said, he couldn't deny what I'd said.

Some things had to be acknowledged. Nanman wasn't the barbaric land people in the Central Plains imagined, and the Beast Miao King wasn't truly a king. He was one of the great chieftains who represented its people.

If I know that much, there's no way Mok doesn't.

Yayul Mok was a decent enough guy, but he was also young and hadn't entirely outgrown his immaturity.

Then, still looking wounded in his pride, he muttered, "You're right. Even my father can't handle all of them alone."

"…?"

"What's that look for?"

"I'm surprised, that's all. Didn't think you'd admit it so readily. Have you grown up a little?"

Did our talk two days ago get through to him?

He still snapped at me like a middle schooler going through puberty, but he was much friendlier than when we'd first met. He even went out of his way to catch wild boar for us.

That's good. The problem is, in this whole enormous land, we've got about a millet grain's worth of people on our side.

I opened my mouth a moment before Yayul Mok could glare at me.

"When and where?"

"Insi. I'll come get you then."

"Good. Oh, and while you're coming…"

"While I'm coming, what?"

"Catch a deer or a roe deer for us. Not another wild boar."

"…!"

A day in Murim was divided into twelve shichen, each about two hours long. Insi was the period from three to five in the morning.

Yayul Mok kept his word. While everyone slept, a White Tiger covered head to tail in snow-white fur cut through the darkness and landed outside our quarters.

Thump.

Alongside it lay a dead animal that looked all too familiar.

"Fuck, another wild boar. You're doing this on purpose, aren't you?"

"Found it on the way."

"You keep finding them. What, do you have a wild-boar farm somewhere? Do you water them, let them grow nice and big, then sneak over and *seori*[2810] them?"

Namho looked puzzled. "What is *seori*? I've never heard that word before."

"It's a thing. And don't worry, Old Man Namho. You won't hear it a second time in this lifetime."

"So that's how you Han Chinese talk…"

"Please stop hating Han Chinese people."

Having politely asked Namho to stop grumbling, I saw Yayul Mok jerk his chin toward the space behind him.

"Get on."

"The tiger?"

"…Would you rather ride on my shoulders?"

"He looks bad-tempered."

[2810] *Seori* is a colloquial Korean term for stealing produce from someone else's field.

"That's prejudice. I've been with him since he was a cub. He's as gentle as can be. Test him if you don't believe me."

"Oh. Really?"

I reached out to stroke the White Tiger's chin—and snatched my hand back like lightning.

Clack!

Its large, sharp teeth snapped shut through empty air. I looked to Yayul Mok for an explanation, and he smacked his lips.

"What a shame."

"You bastard."

"I told you to test him if you didn't believe me. I never said he wouldn't bite."

Having spouted nonsense not even a dog would believe, Yayul Mok gently scratched the White Tiger between the eyes.

"Yaho. Yaho, don't be angry."

For a moment, I thought he was doing an impression of a hiker on Bukhansan.[2811] Then it hit me.

"Wait. Is that his name?"

Yayul Mok nodded proudly.

"Muyaho.[2812] Tiger of the mighty wilds."

"…"

"A magnificent name, isn't it?"

Grrr. Prrr.

Apparently determined to prove it belonged to the cat family, the White Tiger purred. Yayul Mok gazed at it as if he might die from how adorable it was.

"That means he's in a good mood. You can get on now."

"…Uh. Sure."

"Why the look? Is something wrong?"

There is. A little problem only I know about. But I can't say it here.

I swallowed the words on the tip of my tongue and climbed quietly onto the White Tiger's back. Namho followed, his face slightly flushed with excitement.

"To think I'd ride a tiger at my age! They say only warriors are allowed to ride them—and this one's a sacred White Tiger!"

Nothing makes a parent happier than hearing someone praise their child. Yayul Mok, proud mother of Yaho, nodded.

"You know your tigers, old man. Do you like White Tigers?"

[2811] Bukhansan is a mountain near Seoul. *Yaho* is a shout associated with hikers.

[2812] *Muyaho* also echoes a Korean meme catchphrase.

"Of course. I've always liked them very much."[2813]

"…"

No. Stop there. Any further and you're pushing it.

Just as I waited for the next line with equal parts anticipation and dread, the White Tiger stretched leisurely, seemingly unaffected by carrying three people, then kicked off the ground and raced away.

Papat!

Under the bright moon, the three of us rode the tiger through the dark jungle like a streak of light. We stopped before an old shrine that was falling to pieces.

The air inside the shrine was hot and humid as a steam sauna.

Dust coated the floor. Insects had eaten into the pillars. An oil lamp wavered as though it might go out at any moment, casting a dim light through the room.

At the center of it all, someone was waiting for us.

"I hadn't been back in so long, I found the place a mess. Then again, it wasn't in very good shape back then either."

The Beast Miao King, Yayul Cheok, turned toward us. Unlike when we'd first met, his expression was as faint as the lamplight, though the weariness in it was plain to see.

Perhaps that was why none of us asked why he'd chosen to meet us in an old shrine rather than the Inner Palace's main hall. Instead, I took up the thread of his wandering thoughts.

"When was that?"

"When I was young. No, younger than young. We were children. Whenever we caused a disaster too big to put right, we hid here from the adults."

"We?"

"You've met him. I imagine you've already guessed."

"Baeksang. Great chieftain of the Bai people."

The Beast Miao King nodded. "That's right. Him."

"I know you've been together a long time."

"Even 'a long time' isn't enough to describe it. We spent our entire lives together. In the grasslands, the swamps, the mountains and fields, and even on the battlefield—we were always together."

He gazed silently at the wavering lamp for a moment, as though looking back on those days, then gave a small nod.

"Yes. We did."

[2813] "White Tiger" can also be Korean slang for a woman with little or no pubic hair, giving the answer an unintended double meaning.

"I heard you were inseparable childhood friends and sworn brothers."

His eyes moved to me. I met his gaze and went on.

"Are you still?"

"Hmm."

"…Jin Taekyung. Watch your mouth."

Grrrr.

The crouching White Tiger let out a low growl. The Beast Miao King waved a hand at his son, who had stepped forward to warn me, and studied my face.

"You think we aren't?"

"It occurred to me that Great Chieftain Baeksang might not see things the way you do, Palace Lord."

"…"

"I don't know how much you've heard, but all sorts of things are happening in the Central Plains. It started in Shanxi Province, where the Jin Family of Taiyuan is."

I remembered it vividly.

The Shaolin Bloodshed and the Sichuan Blood Tragedy had since overshadowed it, but Dark Heaven had first made its appearance in the Central Plains in Shanxi Province. They manipulated the Mount Heng Sword Sect and its Head Elder into starting a war, and some thousand people lost their lives.

If the Hidden Shadow Pavilion has been keeping him informed, he has to know.

As though he'd read my mind, the Beast Miao King nodded.

"I've heard. I'd met the Blade of Flowers, Jin Baekyang, myself."

"No one saw it coming. It might have been different if he'd been an outsider with no ties to the family. But the Head Elder was our blood kin, one of the Jin Family of Taiyuan's most senior members."

That was why Jin Wikyung had trusted the Head Elder to the end despite his suspicions. The Beast Miao King was sharp enough to understand what I was getting at.

"Baeksang… No. It can't be. He's not like the Blade of Flowers."

"No one knows that."

Namho, who had been watching in silence, spoke up.

"Long ago, I had a subordinate I cherished like family. He was the last descendant of a fallen martial family. The Demonic Cult had killed his parents. Later, when a hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path rose like wildfire in the west, he joined the Murim Alliance. He never feared death on a mission, and the information he brought back won us more than ten small victories."

I'd never heard of this Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent. Neither had the rest of the world.

Namho's face darkened, and so did the story.

“Even after it happened, I couldn’t believe he was a traitor. One day, he sacrificed an arm to bring us information. That information sent more than five thousand Alliance members into the jaws of death.”

“…!”

“When everything was revealed, he fled. And several days later, I saw the head of a man brought back by the assassination squad. He was grinning from ear to ear, as though something had made him terribly happy.”

His voice faded into silence. Namho sighed deeply before he spoke again.

“This old man isn’t saying the Bai great chieftain serves Dark Heaven. But this is Murim. We can’t see an inch ahead of us. Baeksang. Yohi. Heugung. Or one of the thirty-two tribal chiefs gathering here tomorrow. I wouldn’t be surprised if any one of them turned out to be a traitor.”

For a long time, the Beast Miao King said nothing. He watched the oil lamp sway and right itself, over and over, before turning back to me.

“Are you certain?”

“Of one thing, at least.”

“What?”

“The Southern Heaven Demon Empress. That fucking bitch won’t leave Nanman alone.”

The Beast Miao King let out a low groan before opening his mouth.

“Nanman is no easy target.”

“Were the Sichuan Tang Clan, Shaolin Temple, Emei Sect, and Qingcheng Sect easy fucking pushovers, then?”

“…!”

“Oh, sorry. I went too far.”

The Beast Miao King let out a hollow laugh at my sudden outburst before answering.

“You really are Old Master Jeok’s disciple.”

“He’d be offended if he heard you say that.”

“He’d secretly love it.”

“…Oh.”

Okay. He knows Old Man Jeok.

I was giving him a mental thumbs-up when a sudden rush of movement came from outside the shrine.

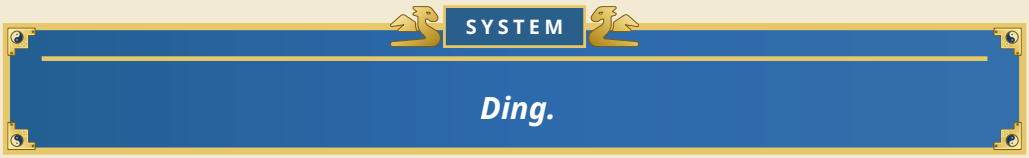
Whoosh, hiss!

A voice followed, held as low as its owner could manage.

“P-Palace Lord!”

At the same moment, a red warning light went off in my head.

And a System alert sounded.


SYSTEM
Ding.

Chapter 633

The voice outside was hushed, but there was no hiding the urgency in it—or the sound of someone approaching.

“P-Palace Lord!”

The Beast Miao King and Yayul Mok snapped their heads up at the call, which seemed to come from one of the guards.

“Something’s happened at Ailao Mountain…!”

Boom!

A powerful wave of qi burst forth and swept through the shrine. The Beast Miao King shattered the decrepit door and glared at his man.

“What do you mean, something’s happened at Ailao Mountain?”

Before his shout reached my ears, a soft chime sounded.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A sudden quest, Unknown Omen, has been generated!

Quest

Unknown Omen

Nanman’s forbidden land, Ailao Mountain, is screaming. Bodies torn to pieces hang from its countless high, treacherous peaks. Blood from something unknown runs down the thousand-fathom cliffs between them. Endless howls pour from the mountain, shrouded in black clouds and mist, filling everyone with fear.

And now, a new path has appeared before you.

Grade: Sudden Quest

Restriction: Jin Taekyung

Mission: Investigate Ailao Mountain within the time limit (Incomplete)

Reward: ???

Failure: ???

Would you like to accept the quest?

Unknown Omen, huh?

The title needed changing. Not *Unknown Omen*, but *Fucking Obvious Omen*.

That aside, there was only one answer I could give.

Accept quest.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have accepted the sudden quest, Unknown Omen!
A time limit has been created!
Time Remaining: 4 hours 59 minutes 59 seconds

The frozen time began to move again. Before even a moment had passed, we set out through the predawn darkness for Ailao Mountain.

The warriors of the Nanman Beast Palace were said to grow up alongside fierce beasts.

From childhood, warrior and beast formed a bond. Once a warrior completed the coming-of-age ceremony and was recognized as a full-fledged warrior, they officially became the beast's owner and companion.

But even a centuries-old tradition had its exceptions.

Whoosh! Rustle!

The Beast Miao King, Yayul Cheok, had no need of a beast's help. He probably never had, even as a child.

He was the greatest warrior Nanman had ever produced—and a beast in his own right.

Leading us through the dark, overgrown jungle, the Beast Miao King let out a mighty roar.

Gwaaaar!

It was a beast's roar in every sense: rougher, more savage, and far more primal than Shaolin Temple's lion's roar, a supreme technique with the power to subdue demons.

His roar tore through the darkness, carrying the warning farther and faster.

Hundreds of torches flared to life here and there below a distant ridge. Looking down at them, the Beast Miao King shouted to the guards running around him.

"Gisan. Dogok. Go to the Outer Palace. Find the tribal chiefs staying there, reassure the people, and mobilize the warriors to prepare for a possible foreign invasion!"

"Yes, sir!"

"Wonhu. Manjeok. You're going to the Inner Palace. Mobilize the Miao warriors and guard the palace!"

"At your command!"

"The remaining three of you, find the other great chieftains and inform them of the situation. Tell each of them to mobilize one hundred elite warriors and head for Ailao Mountain!"

He delivered his orders without missing a beat to the Seven Miao Tigers, his personal guard of the Miao people's finest warriors. Then his gaze moved to his late-born son, running hard behind him.

"Mok."

"…Yes, Father."

The darkness around us wasn't why Yayul Mok looked so grim. He answered faintly, as though he already knew what was coming.

"Go with them," the Beast Miao King said firmly. "Gather the warriors under the Miao people and raise a force in case of trouble."

"But…"

"Have you forgotten? You're the Miao people's Young Chieftain and the Nanman Beast Palace's Young Palace Lord."

It was a reminder of why this man ruled the Nanman Beast Palace. When we'd first met, he'd seemed as easygoing as a well-fed lion. Now he was a beast with prey right in front of him.

And Yayul Mok wasn't childish enough to defy his father's orders at a time like this.

"…I obey, Palace Lord."

Yet he didn't leave us at once. He drew close to me as I ran beside the Beast Miao King and made an unexpected offer.

"Take this one with you."

"Huh?"

Grrr?

He meant White Tiger, which made the offer all the more surprising. Nanman's warriors considered the beasts at their sides their dearest comrades—and family.

Whoosh!

I ducked a branch rushing toward my face and asked cautiously, "Are you giving him away? Putting him up for adoption?"

"Don't be ridiculous!"

Grrrr!

"Whoa. Why are you getting so angry? If it's not, just say no."

"No! If you save even a little strength, you'll be more help to Father!"

Gwaaaar!

So much for man and beast understanding each other without words. They were both throwing the same fucking fit.

Still…

It would definitely be much better to ride him.

My reserves of internal energy were considerable even by Central Plains standards, but they weren't an inexhaustible spring.

If I ended up facing Dark Heaven under the command of the Southern Heaven Demon Empress at Ailao Mountain, then, as Yayul Mok had said, it would be best to conserve as much strength as possible.

Good kid.

I hadn't been in Nanman long, but I knew what it meant for a warrior to lend someone his beast. I gave Yayul Mok an approving look and decided to offer him a gift in return.

"Here. Don't turn it down because you feel bad. Give and take, right?"

Rustle!

For a moment, there was only the wind and the sound of branches brushing past us. Namho, whom I was carrying in both arms like a piece of luggage, spoke with a grave expression.

"Am I an object?"

"If you were, I could at least throw you at someone. I can't even do that with you, Old Man Namho."

"What an insolent thug. You dare suggest attacking an old man…"

"Quit complaining and go. Your retirement plans are looking bright, so don't get dragged into this for no reason. And our kids can't just sit around doing nothing either."

I wasn't dismissing him. I was looking out for him. Namho might be a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent who'd been through every kind of hardship, but he was still an old man who hadn't learned a single move of martial arts.

He knew it better than anyone. He sighed, his face full of worry.

"I'll tell the Fire Dragon Pavilion that the Pavilion Master is looking for them."

"That's enough. I trust you'll tell them what to watch out for, too."

The fuse that was Nanman had finally been lit. The question was who had lit it: an enemy from outside or one within.

Namho's body had aged, but his mind hadn't dulled in the slightest. He gave a small nod.

"Pavilion Master, one last thing."

"Yes?"

"Don't get hurt."

"Ah."

"And dying is even more out of the question."

I gave him a small smile instead of an answer. Yayul Mok took Namho from me, then, with a glance, kicked off White Tiger's back and sprang away.

Tap. Whoosh!

A shadow swept through the hazy moonlight. Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers left our group and disappeared into the darkness. The Beast Miao King, racing on all fours like a gigantic brown bear, picked up his pace.

Crack-crack-crack! Smash!

Thick branches snapped, and dense undergrowth was trampled.

I climbed onto White Tiger's back, which Yayul Mok had left behind, and heard the Beast Miao King's voice through the wind rushing violently past my ears.

"Do you think Dark Heaven is behind this?"

"We'll have to get there to know for sure, but the possibility is high. At the very least, it'll be connected somehow."

His face had gone rigid. I spoke again.

"What exactly is Ailao Mountain?"

"Forbidden land. No one enters without permission."

I already knew that much. Namho had told me on the way here, and the System had just said the same thing. The answer didn't tell me what I wanted to know.

"Isn't the Nanman Beast Palace the same way? Actually, that seems true of most of Nanman."

"It's different. Entirely different. The finest warriors of each tribe go in to keep watch over that place."

"Why would they need to…?"

"This began more than three hundred years ago, when my ancestors' ancestors lived in Nanman. For generations, over a hundred tribes had fought and killed one another across this land. Dozens vanished. The descendants who barely survived founded a sect of their own in Nanman's deepest reaches—and began working with something more dangerous than any blade or beast."

A conversation I'd had with Jeok Cheongang in Henan several months earlier flashed through my mind. We'd spoken of the Nanman Beast Palace's history and its connection to the former Sect Leaders of the Fire Gate Clan. That history was also one reason the palace had joined the Great Faction War.

In that case…

There was only one answer.

"Poison," I murmured. "It was poison."

"Yes. That was the beginning of the Five Poisons Sect, which would terrorize Nanman for the next hundred years."

We crossed a towering peak, leaped from a hill, and raced across the tops of the dense trees. The Beast Miao King swept his clawed hand into a thick tree and sent it flying as he continued.

"Countless people died, they say. Dead fish filled the riverbanks. Beasts ate fish that had washed downstream and died too. Poison spread through the wells, and

an unknown epidemic broke out. After thousands—tens of thousands—had died, the divided tribes finally gathered beneath one banner and began a new war."

That was how the Nanman Beast Palace was born.

But death bred death, and vengeance brought more vengeance. While the Nanman Beast Palace and the Five Poisons Sect fought their bitter war, trapped in that unending cycle, a stranger arrived from the distant Central Plains.

"He called himself the Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan. My ancestors had probably never heard the name, but I doubt that mattered to them. The moment he entered Nanman, he burned to death the hundred Five Poisons Sect warriors who attacked him."

The Sect Leader of that era hadn't appreciated the Five Poisons Sect's unexpectedly grand welcome. Like most martial artists, he hated poison, too.

So he planted his ass on the scales of power, crushed the balance, and led the Nanman Beast Palace in reducing the Five Poisons Sect to ashes.

"The problem came after he left."

The sect's disciples were reduced to bones, but the venomous beasts and fierce animals they released in their final moments multiplied deep in the mountains where their headquarters had stood.

Slowly. Secretly.

And that former headquarters of the Five Poisons Sect was none other than…

"Right there. Ailao Mountain."

I looked up, following the Beast Miao King's pointing finger.

Far in the distance, a black mountain rose into view, its many peaks shrouded in clouds and mist.

Chapter 634

Papat!

Neither the Beast Miao King nor White Tiger slowed. I narrowed my eyes against the chilly wind sweeping over me.

That's Ailao Mountain.

Its rugged slopes and deep valleys were unmistakable even from a distance. Countless mist-shrouded peaks rose high enough to pierce the sky.

Perhaps it was the predawn darkness that had yet to lift. Or perhaps it was knowing this had once been the headquarters of the Five Poisons Sect, which had terrorized Nanman long ago. Whatever the reason, Ailao Mountain looked dark and ominous as it drew closer.

Maybe that was why the Beast Miao King's voice was so low when he spoke.

"The Five Poisons Sect was destroyed by the Palace. But not everything they left behind disappeared."

If people vanished and left things behind, you could simply burn those things. It was different when they had legs.

"No one knew that whatever the Five Poisons Sect had left behind was still living in the deepest reaches of Ailao Mountain."

For more than a hundred years.

The Five Poisons Sect's dark legacy lived on deep within the mountain. In a territory no one else could enter, they devoured one another, bred, and slowly grew in number.

"But our ancestors eventually found out. In a way no one would have wished for."

Three hundred of Nanman's elite warriors dissolved into a handful of bloody water. Two great chieftains and a dozen or so tribal chiefs were torn limb from limb.

It happened at a Tribal Grand Council held on Ailao Mountain, exactly one hundred years after the Nanman Beast Palace destroyed the Five Poisons Sect.

"According to the records, the Palace was attacked by venomous beasts and strange predators rarely seen in Nanman—or anywhere else in the world."

There were deadly poisons with no known antidote, and hundreds of beasts with claws and teeth harder than steel.

The unexpected attack dealt the Nanman Beast Palace devastating losses. They were horrified to find a trace of the Five Poisons Sect, which they had believed was long gone.

"Once again, all of Nanman joined forces. We mobilized every warrior from every tribe, surrounded Ailao Mountain, and set out to kill them."

But the campaign was only half a success.

They killed hundreds of beasts and burned the venomous creatures, but their own losses were too great. And in the process, divisions began to open among the tribes.

When you think about it, how could they not?

Even if you ordered a single pizza to share, someone would get an extra topping and someone else would get less.

The campaign on Ailao Mountain worked much the same way.

Sensing danger, the venomous creatures and fierce beasts popped up everywhere to attack, as though they'd been possessed by Hong Gil-dong.[2814] The tribal chiefs leading the warriors were afraid of how many of their own people they might lose.

They couldn't exactly say, "Since it's come to this, let's have a few people from each tribe die and split it evenly."

"The tribes grew more divided by the day. As a last resort, we tried fire. It spread beyond the mountain and caused even more damage, but it still wasn't enough to burn all of Ailao Mountain."

And so the Nanman Beast Palace had to withdraw. That did not mean they had nothing to show for their losses.

"The Palace suffered terribly, but we reduced the threat just as much. We hunted countless venomous beasts and fierce predators and burned at least part of the mountain. Perhaps the result was only natural."

"What happened after that?"

"Ailao Mountain went quiet, as if nothing had happened. But this time, no one let down their guard. We declared the entire mountain forbidden land and permanently stationed three hundred elite warriors drawn from the tribes there. Every year, the four great chieftains took turns leading small-scale hunts. That is how we kept the peace for more than a hundred years."

For the tribal chiefs of the Nanman Beast Palace, it was a reasonable compromise. They could guard against the threat on Ailao Mountain without suffering such terrible losses again.

The problem was…

"I think that peace ends today."

My voice sank as I pointed ahead.

At the end of the dark, rugged valley, which looked like the entrance to hell, a lone figure sat against a tree.

Whoosh!

The Beast Miao King shot upward like a beam of light, crossed the air, and landed at the mouth of the valley.

[2814] Hong Gil-dong is a legendary Korean outlaw famed for appearing unpredictably in many places.

I followed close behind. By the time I climbed down from White Tiger's back, the Beast Miao King was standing before the figure, his face set like stone.

"…We're too late. He's already dead."

I nodded quietly. I would have known even if he hadn't said it. An indescribable stench had struck my nose before we got within a few steps.

And there was only one cause of death that could produce a smell like that.

Poison. It's poison.

An incredibly potent poison. The figure slumped against the tree—no, the corpse—gave off a stench, and the ground and grass soaked with the bloody fluid seeping from it had turned black and died.

Unless a martial artist had cultivated Scorching Yang Qi, rooted in the fire qi that countered poison, even an early Peak master would have trouble withstanding the poisonous qi within three zhang[2815] of the body.

Grrr.

I soothed White Tiger, whose brow was deeply furrowed, and spoke.

"Do you recognize him?"

"He looks familiar, though I can't place him. He must be one of the warriors stationed on Ailao Mountain."

"Do you usually post a guard at the entrance?"

"Of course not. We need every warrior on the mountain in case something happens. It covers such a vast area that there are three or four villages nearby, but the villagers know all this well enough."

In other words, the area had been strictly controlled for so long that there was no need for another sentry.

Which meant…

He came down from the mountain. He was running from something.

I looked around.

Beyond the thick darkness, faint but unmistakable footprints remained. They were clearly human. I could see no tracks left by a beast or any venomous creature.

There was something else, too.

"There's a wound. Look at his side."

As the Beast Miao King said, the clothing at the corpse's side was torn as though something had clawed it, and the skin beneath was black.

"It wasn't a weapon. Looks like something rough and powerful barely grazed him, but…"

"That is what makes poison frightening. A small wound can kill in moments."

[2815] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft); three zhang is about 9.09 meters (29.8 ft).

He had only been scratched, and it had done this much damage. Was it anything like the Formless Ultimate Poison that had once afflicted Jeok Cheongang?

I took my eyes off the corpse and stared into the dark valley. I had not seen what happened, but I could almost picture it.

Until a short while ago, the nameless warrior must have been running through that rugged valley. Poisoned, stumbling and staggering, he had fled in a panic before dying beneath the tree.

It was tragic. But right now, I needed to know what had killed him.

Was it Dark Heaven? One of Ailao Mountain's venomous beasts? Or...

A venomous beast from Ailao Mountain controlled by Dark Heaven.

With that question unanswered, I turned to the Beast Miao King.

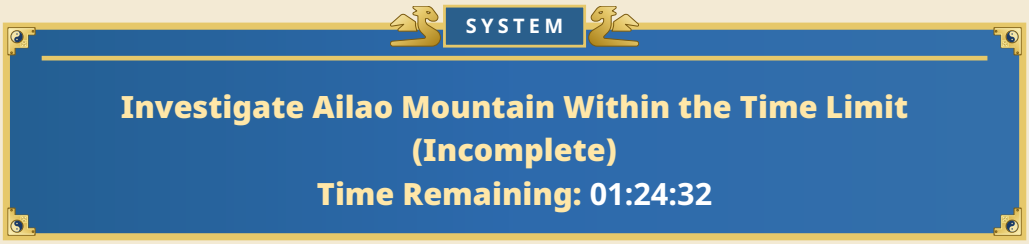
"In the end, it seems there's only one answer."

"Yes."

His voice was the growl of an enraged beast.

"I'll see for myself which bastard did this."

Ding.



It should have been growing light by now, but Ailao Mountain remained steeped in darkness.

And darkness was not the only thing there.

The scent of blood.

The smell had become familiar to me at some point. Now it served as an invisible guide. Following the dead warrior's footprints through the mountain, the Beast Miao King and I caught the scent on the damp wind and changed course without hesitation.

At last, we found them.

Countless bodies lay scattered across the ridges. The stench of deadly poison overwhelmed even the thick smell of blood.

"...!"

"...!"

How many were there? A hundred? More?

The grim possibility that had occurred to me when we found the body in the valley was now before my eyes.

At the horrific sight, the Beast Miao King's eyes blazed.

"What bastard dares…? I'll tear him limb from limb!"

For the ruler of the Nanman Beast Palace, it was only natural to be furious. But instead of joining him, I kept as calm as I could. I drew up my internal energy, formed a qi curtain to keep any sound from escaping, and examined the bodies.

Broken bones. Bruises. Severed limbs. Poisoning.

Unlike the first warrior, these people had died in different ways. Some had been killed with their limbs crushed. More than a few had parts of their bodies—their necks, among other things—torn away by some unknown, tremendous force.

Anyone chosen to guard Ailao Mountain must have been skilled.

Yet they had been slaughtered like this.

From what I had seen, the Beast Miao King, Baeksang, and a handful of others stood out, while most Nanman warriors were less skilled than those of the Central Plains. Even so, these elite warriors would have been First Rate at minimum, with some at Supreme First Rate and perhaps a rare Peak master among them.

And Nanman warriors don't fight alone. With the beasts that accompany them, they should be a match for a major sect of the Central Plains…

I broke off as something felt wrong. Then I saw White Tiger watching our surroundings with a low growl and realized what it was.

The beasts. Where did they go?

The beasts that were always at their warriors' sides, as inseparable as parts of their own bodies, were gone.

I looked around quickly. Among what had to be more than a hundred human corpses, I could see only three or four dead beasts.

"Why?"

The moment I voiced the question—

Hsssss.

"…!"

A chilling presence rode the wind toward us, piercing me like an awl.

The Beast Miao King, who had barely managed to contain his rage, and I both turned our heads like lightning.

We saw it. Heard it.

Rustle.

Far away, grass stirred faintly. Darkness rippled as though it were alive. And then —

Grrr.

A low growl, deep as an abyss, came from something crouched in the dark grass.

Step.

In a world that seemed to slow, the darkness moved, trampling the grass beneath it.

Wrapped head to toe in black, it came toward us. It was larger than any beast I had ever seen, and its blue-white eyes held unmistakable anger and majesty.

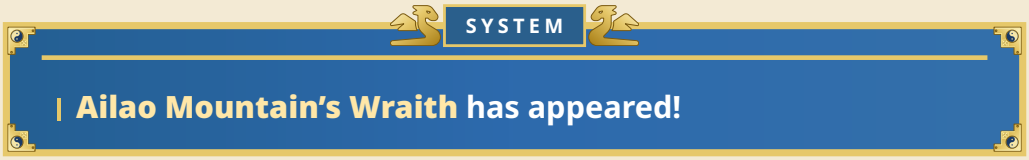
Black Tiger.

The word flashed through my mind like lightning. At that exact moment, White Tiger's body began to tremble.

Gwaaaaaaaaaang!

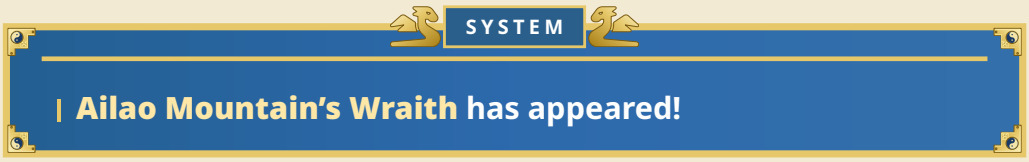
A roar tore through the darkness, shaking heaven and earth. At the same time, a familiar chime rang in my ears.

Ding.



Chapter 635

Ding.



Ailao Mountain's Wraith.

A being and a name I had never seen or heard of before.

Before I could process the new information, the colossal Black Tiger the System had named Ailao Mountain's Wraith let out a thunderous roar.

Gwaaaaaaaaaang!

The roar tore through the darkness and echoed across the entire mountain. The air around us rippled like water, and grass and branches shattered.

This was no ordinary beast's cry.

It was something primal, drawing out the fear hidden deep in the heart and shaking the soul itself.

And I knew the nature of that power better than anyone else in this world.

Fear.

I had known instinctively from the moment I met its blue-white eyes: the enormous creature that had appeared before us could not be fully described as a mere beast.

I knew because, a few months ago in Hubei, I had encountered something like it.

The Water God Dragon.

The master of Dongting Lake, driven mad and stripped of its reason by Dark Heaven. A rare spiritual creature that had entered a new realm after hundreds of years.

I sensed qi like the Water God Dragon's emanating from the Black Tiger towering like Taishan, and I was not the only one who felt it.

Whine…

By any ordinary standard, White Tiger deserved to be called a spiritual creature. But it was no match for that overwhelming Fear.

While White Tiger whimpered like a frightened puppy, someone else stepped forward without the slightest hesitation.

"Was this your doing?"

Boom!

With a furious shout, the Beast Miao King kicked off the ground. In the blink of an

eye, he had covered more than ten zhang.[2816]

Radiant light burst from his tightly clenched fist.

Whoooosh!

His fist split the air with a heavy rush. Destructive Force coiled around it like thread, erasing everything in its path.

And at the end of that path…

Slash!

Nothing.

Only empty air.

"…!"

"…!"

It had dodged a punch from a Supreme Peak master counted among the Ten Kings.

It had happened in an instant. The Black Tiger moved through the darkness like mist, evading the Beast Miao King's attack, then swung its enormous front paw, black as night.

Swish!

Unbelievably fast. And powerful.

Boom! Crack-crack-crack!

A deafening impact sent a tremendous shock wave in every direction. Driven back by the force of the blow, the Beast Miao King's eyes widened.

"What the…?"

He had no time to recover from his shock. A hungry predator did not hesitate before its prey.

Gwaaaaaaaaaang!

Another roar shook Ailao Mountain.

In the modern world, Gates and monsters had become part of everyday life. But the martial artists of this world were not accustomed to Fear.

The Beast Miao King had been caught off guard all the more because he had never encountered a creature so far beyond anything he expected.

"Kh!"

He froze for the barest instant. That was probably the best the Beast Miao King could have managed, but a life-and-death duel between masters could be decided by just such an opening.

That held true even when the opponent was a beast rather than a martial artist.

Whoosh!

In a world that seemed to slow, the Black Tiger's hooked claws tore through the air.

[2816] A *zhang* here is ten Korean *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten zhang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

At that moment, a spear left my hand and streaked across the space between us in a flash of light.

Shreeeek! Boom!

A roar split the heavens. Everything within a radius of more than ten zhang[2817] shook.

Qi against qi. Strength against strength.

And I won that brief clash.

Crack!

The Black Tiger flew backward as though it had become one with the spear and vanished beyond the dark forest. In the distance, dozens of towering trees snapped and swayed.

The mountain birds that had long since awakened and must have been watching us in silence took flight all at once, while countless leaves and branches poured down like a rain shower.

Tap. Rustle!

Now was the time to catch it.

But I had barely started after the Black Tiger when I had to stop.

Why can't I sense it…?

I could not feel its presence. Not even a trace.

All it had left behind was wreckage that looked as though a bomb had gone off, and a spear lying on the ground with its blade shattered.

There were no footprints. No bloodstains.

It got beyond the range of my Qi Sense? That quickly?

As I searched the surroundings, the Beast Miao King arrived with White Tiger. Anger and shame mingled on his face.

"Where is it?"

"It seems to have run away. I can't find it."

"…Damn it. You saw me at my worst."

"I understand. I mean that."

Mungyeong and Jeok Cheongang had both been shaken for a moment by the Water God Dragon's Fear.

The Beast Miao King was a formidable master, worthy of his place among the Ten Kings. But comparing him to those two, who had reached a realm beyond humanity, would hardly be fair.

If anything, he had shaken off the Fear faster than I expected.

Maybe growing up in Nanman, surrounded by strange venomous beasts and ferocious animals, had helped. I could not say.

[2817] A *zhang* here is ten Korean *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten zhang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

What mattered right now was something else.

"It's still alive. There's no blood, so it doesn't seem to have suffered any significant injury."

The Beast Miao King nodded at my quiet words.

"I thought as much. When it knew it couldn't dodge, it bit down on the spearhead at the last moment. A spearhead wreathed in Force, no less. I've lived in Nanman all my life, but I've never seen or heard of anything like it."

"I don't think that's true."

"What do you mean?"

"The last part."

Before he could reply, I went on.

"You may never have seen one, but you've heard of one. I'm sure of it."

We could not sense the Black Tiger for now, but it might spring out at any moment. The Beast Miao King had put his back to mine as we watched our surroundings. At my words, he stiffened.

"Could it be…?"

"You're probably thinking of the right thing. Something similar happened in Hubei Province."

"…You mean that imugi?"[2818]

The words came out like a groan. He continued, "The Murim Alliance mentioned it in a letter. But I thought the story sounded far-fetched."

"Are you really the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace? Your only son rides around on a White Tiger, and you couldn't believe that?"

"He rides a White Tiger, not an imugi."[2819]

"…Ah."

Fair enough.

An imugi[2820] belonged in myth. Even coming from the Murim Alliance, the story would have been hard to believe.

His brief, blunt answer left me with nothing to say. The Beast Miao King spoke up abruptly.

"If that is the case, was that creature that just appeared also the work of the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—that witch?"

"I can't be sure. But it's likely."

Too much about this felt wrong for me to rule it out.

Ailao Mountain had been quiet for more than a hundred years, despite once being the Five Poisons Sect's headquarters. Now a massacre had happened here, and a

[2818] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.
[2819] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.
[2820] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.

Black Tiger of astonishing power had appeared. It all reminded me of the Water God Dragon.

Ailao Mountain's Wraith.

What was it really?

Where were the two hundred warriors who should still have been here, aside from the people now sprawled around us as cold corpses? And where were the ferocious beasts they commanded?

I was slowly scanning the area with a heavy gaze when—

Grrr.

Having barely recovered from the Fear, White Tiger suddenly crouched low and raised its tail high.

The Beast Miao King and I understood what that meant and turned at once.

Far away, the darkness was rippling.

That's…!

We had both overlooked something while we talked.

An animal's sense of smell was dozens, even hundreds of times keener than a human's. A tiger, which usually hunted at night, had a nose to match.

Which meant…

White Tiger can smell farther than my Qi Sense can reach.

The moment it clicked, the Beast Miao King and I kicked off the ground together.

As we chased it, I learned exactly why people called tigers mountain lords.[2821]

Ah. Look at that fucking bastard.

I swallowed the curse and glared at the black shape racing far ahead.

No matter how far we ran along the winding ridges, no matter how many cloud- and mist-covered peaks we crossed, we could not catch it.

Its strength, inexhaustible Stamina, and elusive movements kept it ahead of the Beast Miao King and me. Even White Tiger—a spiritual creature with white fur to boast of—could not catch up.

If anything, White Tiger was growing more anxious by the moment.

No wonder. That's no ordinary tiger.

A *mountain lord* was not just the king of a mountain. The term could also refer to a mountain spirit. But that creature was no spirit of Ailao Mountain.

It was its wraith. Perhaps something still more ominous: an evil spirit.

What we saw as we pursued the Black Tiger only strengthened that thought.

[2821] *San-gun*, literally "mountain lord," is a traditional epithet for a tiger and can also refer to a mountain spirit.

“That damned beast…!”

The Beast Miao King’s voice seemed to boil like lava. His furious gaze had fallen on bodies with their limbs hanging limp.

Deep valleys. The edges of cliffs. Ravines that must once have run clear but had now been stained black by poison…

The corpses of Nanman warriors lay along our route like signposts. The wind carried a sickening mix of blood and foul odors.

“How dare they? How dare they do something like this!”

A savage wave of qi poured from the Beast Miao King as the horrific sights flashed past us.

He was angrier than ever, and his movements grew rougher with it.

“You bastard!”

Tap-tap—shreeeek!

In an instant, his body shot forward at a terrifying speed and streaked toward the Black Tiger without hesitation.

But his opponent was a creature called Ailao Mountain’s Wraith. A head-on fight might be another matter; in natural physique and speed, the Beast Miao King could not match it.

Papat!

Just as I expected.

The Black Tiger, far beyond an ordinary spiritual creature, pulled farther ahead instead of being caught. Soon it vanished into a deep, dark valley.

It gave us a look that seemed to say, *Come and get me if you dare.*

What?

Only then did I slow down and look around.

Ancient trees and vines filled every direction, while the hot, humid air mixed with mist carried the distinctive stench of poison.

I did not know exactly where we were, but after running mindlessly in pursuit of the creature, I could at least guess that we had reached the heart of Ailao Mountain.

This…

I had a bad feeling. A very bad feeling.

But while I slowed, the Beast Miao King charged straight into the valley without a hint of hesitation.

“Great Hero Yayul, wait—!”

Crack!

There was no time to stop him. Even if there had been, he would not have listened.

A little anger could wake a dulled mind. Too much could put it to sleep.

“Damn it.”

I muttered under my breath and looked at White Tiger, which had gone quiet.

It was pacing anxiously at the valley entrance where the Beast Miao King had disappeared, as though it had already sensed the danger. When it met my eyes, it shook its head like a person.

“Was that supposed to mean it’s dangerous?”

Grrr.

“This guy’s pretty smart. We agreed for the first time. But there’s nothing we can do this time.”

Grrr…

“You don’t have to come. Go back from here, and if you run into your master or anyone else, tell them we’re here.”

White Tiger was clever enough to count as a spiritual creature. I trusted it had understood me.

As Yayul Mok had done, I gently stroked it between the eyes, then stepped toward the valley.

Without a trace of fear.

With my head held high.

“…”

I’ll make it back alive, right?

Chapter 636

The valley was narrow and dark. Trees too old for me to guess their age grew thick enough to block the moonlight, and strange plants and creatures I had never seen before filled the space around me.

Some of them were aggressive, too.

Hiss!

I was moving with my movement technique when I reached out. Something shot from the grass like lightning and writhed in my grip.

Chrit. Chrit!

What is this? A snake?

A closer look told me I was half right.

It was a snake, but no ordinary one. Horns grew from either side of its triangular head.

Wait. Haven't I seen this somewhere before?

I stared at it and muttered, "Mimi… No, a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake?"

Chrit.

Why was one here? Wasn't the Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake supposed to be rare even across the whole world?

Now that I look again, it does seem a little different.

Maybe it was because this place was basically China. Knockoffs everywhere.

Compared to Mimi, its body was larger, but its sheen and horns were less impressive.

I stared at the snake in disbelief, then threw it into the distance and picked up speed. Whether it was a Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake or not, I had been right about one thing: this valley was not safe.

Is it a trap after all?

I had spent a little time before entering, and the Black Tiger and the Beast Miao King were already far ahead. At least the Beast Miao King had left tracks here and there. The Black Tiger had left none, as though it really were a wraith.

Swish, swish, swish!

After running for about half a gak[2822], I spotted a vast swamp drawing closer in the distance. A familiar figure stood at its center.

"Great Hero Yayul! Stop! Stop charging in headfirst!"

"…I've already stopped."

He had. The Beast Miao King still looked furious, but he stood perfectly still amid the bodies of venomous beasts and ferocious animals.

[2822] A gak is a traditional time interval of about fifteen minutes; half a gak is about seven and a half minutes.

“What happened here?”

“They came at me from every direction like mad things. I lost sight of it because of them.”

Humans and beasts alike knew better than to attack someone stronger without good reason. If anything, beasts were more cautious because their instincts were sharper.

Yet these creatures had blocked the Beast Miao King’s path.

“Were they doing it for the Black Tiger?”

“I don’t know. But whatever their reason, it isn’t strange. This land has always been like this. It was probably the same a hundred years ago. Two hundred, too.”

That was an odd answer. He sounded as though he had known about this place all along.

When I gave him a questioning look, he continued, his expression hard.

“In the past, unlike the other tribes, the Five Poisons Sect focused on raising venomous beasts rather than ferocious animals.”

Poison was scorned everywhere, but it was an efficient weapon. Especially for the Five Poisons Sect. They had made enemies of everyone else in Nanman and faced opponents who outnumbered them dozens of times over.

“The place they created was called the Poisonblood Grounds. The most savage and vicious beasts and venomous creatures in all Nanman—perhaps in the entire world—ran rampant there. It was the deadliest and most secret legacy the Five Poisons Sect left behind.”

“Are you saying this is…”

The Beast Miao King nodded.

“The Poisonblood Grounds.”

“Huh. No wonder there wasn’t a path. But it doesn’t seem as dangerous as you made it sound. I can still breathe.”

Granted, I had met a knockoff Thousand-Year Poison Horned Snake on the way, and poisonous air seeped into me like carbonation with every breath. So far, though, I was doing all right.

Then the Beast Miao King spoke again.

“Of course. We’re on the outskirts of the Poisonblood Grounds. This is only the entrance.”

“The entrance?”

“According to the records, a little over a hundred years ago, each tribe in Nanman selected only its finest warriors to enter the Poisonblood Grounds. They carried hundreds of jars filled with lamp oil and held poison-warding pearls in their mouths. What do you think happened?”

“I’m guessing they didn’t all come home safely and live happily ever after.”

“Not one returned. The whole undertaking came to nothing. It is the chief reason Ailao Mountain remains forbidden to this day.”

I followed his pointing finger to a huge swamp that stretched for hundreds of zhang.[2823] Mist hung over it.

“By the way,” I asked cautiously, “is the fog around here usually green?”

“Of course not. Fog is usually white.”

“That fog is green.”

“Ah. That is because it’s Poison Mist.”

“…”

He said it as casually as a mother announcing that dinner was soybean-paste stew. I took a moment to collect myself.

“…Where exactly have you brought me?”

“The Poisonblood Grounds.”

“…”

For fuck’s sake. He calls that an answer?

The Beast Miao King smacked his lips at my stare.

“I didn’t know until we came in. Even the records didn’t give the Poisonblood Grounds’ exact location.”

This was a goddamn mess. Wondering whether White Tiger could lead the others this far, I asked, “Then what’s deeper inside?”

“How would I know? Everyone died.”

“That’s incredibly reassuring.”

“Baeksang’s grandfather died there, too. He was Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace at the time. I’ve heard he was the strongest warrior in the history of the Bai people.”

The Palace Lord’s position did not pass down through a single family. Yayul Mok was only the nominal Young Palace Lord. If the position became vacant, the Tribal Grand Council would convene, and one of the great chieftains of the four most powerful tribes would be elected Palace Lord.

“Stronger than you, Great Hero Yayul?”

“I cannot say. The measure of strength changes with the times. But had he lived in my era, I would not be surprised if we had a Beast Bai King instead of a Beast Miao King.”

For the Beast Miao King to speak of him like that, Baeksang’s grandfather must have been at least a Supreme Peak master by Central Plains standards—someone who had opened the Middle Dantian, or gone beyond it.

[2823] A zhang is a traditional length of ten chi, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft) using the chapter’s traditional length scale.

And a master like that died in the Poisonblood Grounds alongside Nanman's finest warriors.

And the even bigger problem is that I have to go in there now.

Still…

"We've come this far. We can't turn back now. Let's go."

The Beast Miao King looked surprised by how calmly I said it.

"That is unexpected. I thought you would suggest turning back."

"Someone once said that if a man draws his sword, he should cut through even the Poisonblood Grounds."

"…Who said that?"

"I did."

He gave me a dubious look, then grinned.

"Elder Jeok raised his Disciple well."

"Well, technically, there was a lot of violence and oppression involved… But why get into every little detail? You won't listen to me no matter what I say, Great Hero Yayul."

"Did that even need saying?"

Crack.

Bones ground in his tightly clenched fist. His voice turned cold.

"I am the great chieftain of the Miao people, but I am also Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace. I must make someone pay for their blood."

Perhaps that was why he had become Palace Lord.

I was looking at him in a new light when he spoke again.

"Thank you. For helping me."

"What else could I do? People died. I couldn't leave you here alone and go back."

"Even if Dark Heaven isn't in there?"

"I'm not that much of a coward."

A faint smile touched his lips.

"I hear the Central Plains calls men like you chivalrous heroes."

"People who dislike me usually call me a fucking bastard. I get called a lunatic a lot, too."

It was true, so I wasn't offended. Besides, most of the people who had called me those things had died by my hand. People really ought to watch what they say.

A chivalrous hero.

I still didn't know if I was one. I had done one thing, then another, and somehow ended up here with people calling me that.

A chivalrous hero in the Central Plains. A hero in the modern world. What did it matter? Whatever anyone called me, I had always done what I wanted. Dark Heaven just happened to be something I particularly couldn't stand.

Fine. Let's take on whatever's in there.

Alone, I might have had reason to worry. With the Beast Miao King beside me, we had a chance even if the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was waiting inside.

Step.

I had just finished my thoughts and followed the Beast Miao King into the swamp shrouded in deep green poisonous mist when—

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest condition: Investigate Ailao Mountain Within the Time Limit has been completed!
Unexpected Quest: Unknown Omen has been successfully completed!
Quest completion rewards have been granted!
A small amount of EXP and Fame has been acquired!
High-Grade Antidote ×20 acquired!

The System notifications came without warning. And they did not stop there.

Ding.

SYSTEM

You have entered the hidden location Poisonblood Grounds!
Poisonblood Grounds is the most secret location created by the former Five Poisons Sect. Here, they raised countless venomous beasts and produced deadly poisons that could not be cured.
You have achieved the extremely rare Achievement How'd You Find This?
You have acquired a High-Grade Poison-Warding Pearl as an Achievement reward!
A Chain Quest has been created!
Would you like to accept the Quest My Good Sir, Do Not Cross That Swamp?[2824]

"…"

[2824] The Quest title echoes *My Love, Don't Cross That River*, the English title of a Korean documentary.

For fuck's sake. Look at that quest title.

The longer I stared at the holographic window, the less I wanted to answer. In the end, I nodded.

SYSTEM

Quest My Good Sir, Do Not Cross That Swamp has been accepted!

Then I instinctively sighed in the deep green Poison Mist, and realized—

Beep.

SYSTEM

The penalty effect of Poison Mist has activated!

"…!"

Something had gone seriously wrong.

Beep! Beep! Beep-beep-beep!

SYSTEM

Poison permeating the air is entering your body through your respiratory tract and skin!

Due to your traits, Myriad-Poison Immunity and Scorching Yang Qi, the penalty from Poisoned has been reduced!

You have been afflicted with the Mildly Poisoned status abnormality!

All stats have decreased by 10!

If Mildly Poisoned persists for a certain length of time, the penalty effect will increase and may even result in death!

"…"

One sigh was enough to poison me?

If the poison entered through my skin, holding my breath wouldn't help, either.

What the fuck kind of bullshit is this?

It was absurd, but I held back. As it happened, I had just the thing for a situation like this.

Open Inventory. Summon.

I took out a ring set with a black jewel that gleamed in the light. It was the Myriad-Poison Ring, a divine artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan. As soon as I slipped it onto my finger, a System notification told me the status abnormality had been removed. The heaviness that had briefly settled over my body lifted.

Just as I thought.

I smiled contentedly and stroked the Myriad-Poison Ring. Then I noticed someone silently glaring at me and flinched.

“Oh. You startled me. What is it?”

“…Hngh. Poison. Hngh. Don’t talk to me. Hngh.”

Oh, right. He was here too.

I gave the Beast Miao King a flat, chilled stare and tossed him the High-Grade Poison-Warding Pearl I had received as the Achievement completion reward.

Chapter 637

This was a first.

The first time I had crossed a swamp this long and wide.

The first time I had fought things that weren't human while breathing Poison Mist like ordinary air.

Splash!

A sudden sound came from behind me. I pivoted smoothly and brought down my straightened hand like a blade.

Slash!

From what I could see, the thing was easily more than three zhang[2825] long.

But neither its sharp teeth nor its armor-thick hide could stop the qi in my knife-hand.

The enormous crocodile looked like something from a documentary about the Amazon. It split in half and fell onto the blackened water.

Splash!

The fishy smell of blood and an even fouler stench rose from it, but I only felt sick for a moment. I was holding up much better than I'd expected.

Then again, I'd been covered for some time in slime and blood that smelled worse than sewage.

This isn't exactly fighting fire with fire.

Nanman Life Pro Tip: If you're worried about a bad smell, get used to an even worse one.

"…Fuck."

I had a brief moment of clarity, but the Poisonblood Grounds—shittier than working two shifts loading and unloading trucks—wouldn't even allow me that much.

Swish!

A snake hidden in the swamp shot toward my neck like an arrow.

The moment it bared its black, razor-sharp fangs and opened its jaws wide toward my thigh—

Whack!

Fingers as thick as the branches of a great tree blew its triangular head away.

No question it was dead. The Beast Miao King caught its limp tail, slammed it into the swamp, and spoke with a grave expression.

"Dohn' led yer gar' down."

"Don't let my what?"

[2825] A zhang is ten cheok, approximately 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

"Be gareful."

"...Ah. Right."

Roughly translated: Don't let your guard down. Be careful. Something like that.

Nanman's greatest warrior, now over eighty years old, was speaking less clearly than an eight-year-old because his mouth was stuffed with the poison-warding pearl.

"Almos' dere."

That pronunciation sounded awfully familiar.

I wanted to ask if he was from somewhere around Gyeongsang-do, but I held back. This was hardly the time, and just as the Beast Miao King had said, the swamp really was coming to an end.

That didn't mean things had gotten any better.

Open Quest Window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest

My Good Sir, Do Not Cross That Swamp

You have entered the Poisonblood Grounds.
Deep within Ailao Mountain, once the headquarters of the Five Poisons Sect, lies this most secluded and secret place. It is home to life-forms unknown and undiscovered.
A cursed land filled with poison-laden mist and the spirits of countless dead.
No one can tell you what awaits beyond it. You have no choice but to see for yourself.

Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: ???
Reward: ???
Failure: Death

"..."

No matter how many times I looked at it, this was ridiculous.

It had been a while since I'd seen a Quest window this short. The mission and reward were a mystery, but one thing was clear: fail and you die.

Then again, it had always worked like that. In the modern world's Gates and here in Murim alike.

Win and live. Lose and die.

Simple, brutal logic.

Hunters and Murim practitioners alike were people who always lived with one foot in the Sanzu River.[2826]

And just as I had every other time, I had no intention of dying now.

Splash.

When the swamp ended, relatively soft ground appeared. Every time the foul-smelling slime fell to the ground in the wake of my and the Beast Miao King's footsteps, I could see the already blackish earth around us becoming even darker.

"Vile."

The Beast Miao King spat out the poison-warding pearl and continued as he looked around.

"This is only the second time in my life I've seen a place this horrible."

"What was the first?"

"The Great Faction War. Everywhere we went, there was a hellscape."

He was comparing the Poisonblood Grounds to a war in which hundreds of thousands had slaughtered one another. That said enough about this place.

Fwoooosh.

Poison Mist rolled toward us over the blackened earth. The Beast Miao King swallowed a groan at the grim sight.

"Damn it. If I'd known this would happen, I'd have trained in poison arts when I was young."

"You didn't know. Isn't that why you never learned them?"

The Beast Miao King nodded regretfully.

"Yes. I thought my own martial arts were enough. It's why I never learned the beast-taming techniques everyone else studied, either."

"That makes sense. Why learn something you don't need?"

I suddenly felt a strange sense of kinship.

In the modern world, people gave up on math or English. In Nanman, they gave up on poison arts or beast taming. For the record, I'd given up on every subject when I took the college entrance exam.

"Come to think of it, I thought everyone in Nanman learned poison arts."

"If they did, wouldn't this be the Nanman Poison Palace instead of the Nanman Beast Palace?"

"…Oh."

"That is a prejudice held by people from the Central Plains. It is true that the nature of Nanman's land means we encounter poison easily, but most tribes primarily deal with ferocious beasts. After the Five Poisons Sect rose to power, we rejected poison even more strongly. You can tell just by looking at the divine artifact passed down through our Palace for generations."

[2826] The Sanzu River is a Buddhist river associated with the boundary between life and death.

“Oh, I see… Wait.”

What did he just say?

I stopped for a moment and stared at the Beast Miao King. He frowned and looked back at me.

“What?”

“What you just said.”

“That we came to reject poison arts? After the harm this Palace suffered, it was only natural.”

“Not that. The divine artifact. You said there was a divine artifact.”

“Ah. That. I thought you meant something else.”

The Beast Miao King answered as if it were nothing, but from my perspective, it wasn’t something I could simply brush off with an *Oh, I see.*

“The Nanman Beast Palace had a divine artifact?”

“Any faction with a long history is bound to have one. From what I have seen, that is even truer in the Central Plains.”

He wasn’t wrong. Mid-sized sects and even neighborhood martial arts schools would hang an old iron sword on the wall, call it a divine artifact, and hope it made them look important.

But some objects truly deserved the name.

The Green Jade Buddha Staff was one: the divine artifact of Shaolin Temple, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim, whose lineage stretched back a thousand years.

And for some reason, Dark Heaven was targeting those very divine artifacts.

They had even caused the major incident known as the Shaolin Bloodshed to do so.

And the Nanman Beast Palace had one too?

As far as I knew, the Palace was more than three hundred years old.

An Outer Lands power formed by an alliance of dozens of tribes, it had arisen in the struggle against the Five Poisons Sect and, after a long war, become the dominant force in Nanman.

It wouldn’t be strange for it to have a divine artifact. What mattered was that this was the first I’d heard of it.

“I’ve never heard that the Nanman Beast Palace had a divine artifact.”

I did my best to sound calm. The Beast Miao King nodded.

“Of course not. It disappeared not long after the Palace was founded.”

“What?”

“Then again, it may never have existed. The Beast King Stone has been passed down from Palace Lord to Palace Lord as a legend. No one can even say for certain it was real.”

"The Beast King Stone…"

Its name alone was extraordinary. The Beast Miao King nodded at my quiet murmur and continued.

"As I said, it is a legend. A divine artifact carried by the first Palace Lord, said to make every ferocious beast under heaven obey him. It supposedly vanished after he and the founding Sect Leader of the Five Poisons Sect grievously wounded each other in battle."

A stone with the miraculous power to command every ferocious beast under heaven. That was a legend if I'd ever heard one.

And one passed down by word of mouth for hundreds of years, at that.

If I started working on it right now, then in a few hundred years, I could insist that I had been born from an egg.

Still, I should keep the Beast King Stone in mind…

For now, though, it was far more plausible that the Southern Heaven Demon Empress meant to create a "rift" in Nanman than that she was after a legendary stone no one could even prove existed.

"By the way…"

"Yes?"

The Beast Miao King glanced between me and the Poison Mist, then hesitated.

"That. Do you have another one?"

By *that*, he meant the Myriad-Poison Ring.

I gave him a firm answer.

"No."

"Then let me borrow it for a moment—"

"Hey, Mr. Yayul. Cut the nonsense and put the poison-warding pearl back in your mouth."

"…What did you just say?"

"Ah. My tongue slipped for a moment. If you don't want to get poisoned, keep the poison-warding pearl in your mouth."

The Beast Miao King shot me a displeased look, but then put the large poison-warding pearl in his mouth without another word.

He might have held the lowest seat among the Ten Kings, but he was still a master worthy of belonging to them.

With martial prowess that had reached such a lofty realm and a vast reserve of internal energy, poison was unlikely to overcome him easily. Even so, a little precaution never hurt.

A High-Grade Poison-Warding Pearl should keep most ordinary poisons from penetrating.

And I had the Myriad-Poison Ring, a divine artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan.

The Beast Miao King looked at me enviously before stepping into the Poison Mist.

Step.

His footfall sounded unusually loud.

Deep green mist covered everything, so thick I could barely see in front of me. The silence was just as strange.

As if something is watching its prey.

I could feel something watching us through the dense Poison Mist. Why, then, was it quieter here than in the swamp?

I wasn't the only one who noticed.

—A small patch of grass ten or so zhang[2827] away. Northwest. Do you sense it?

A Sound Transmission reached my ear. I gave a small nod.

—The grass beside the rock?

—Yes. Something is there. Could it be…

I thought of Ailao Mountain's Wraith. The ghostlike presence I had felt from it, and its ray-like movements.

—It isn't the wraith. Even if it were, we couldn't catch it from this distance.

—That depends on how we go about it.

The Beast Miao King thrust out a palm like lightning.

Boom!

Compressed air burst outward, scattering the thick mist for an instant.

Through the brief opening, I saw his powerful palm force sweep over the grass like a storm.

And then…

"Guh!"

There was a scream. Not the cry of a beast, but unmistakably the scream of a human.

"…!"

"…!"

The Beast Miao King and I stared at each other, eyes wide, then shot toward the source of the cry like lightning.

Whoooosh!

Countless thoughts flashed through my mind as I cut through the mist.

But the first two words that came to me were Dark Heaven.

It's them.

Who else would be in Ailao Mountain, Nanman's forbidden land—let alone here in the Poisonblood Grounds?

[2827] A zhang is ten cheok, approximately 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

A jolt ran through my entire body. My heart pounding, I closed the distance of ten or so zhang[2828] in an instant.

Then I saw who had been flung out of the grass, and the words escaped me.

“What the hell…?”

Dark red blood stained the corner of his mouth. His eyes were wide open.

There was no doubt that he was a human corpse, but he was wearing clothing that was painfully familiar to both me and someone else.

“…Why is a Bai warrior here?”

The confusion in the Beast Miao King’s hollow voice matched my own. The man who had been alive only moments ago was a Bai warrior.

His body, dressed in white garments like a burial shroud, was tightly wrapped in something sticky and tough.

Rope. No, thread?

The Beast Miao King and I stared, unable to make sense of it.

That was when—

Rustle. Rustle-rustle.

When had they gotten there? Where had they been hiding?

Along with the countless presences approaching from every direction, I suddenly felt darkness settle over my head. I looked up.

At last, I saw them.

Hissss!

Some beings descended like ghosts from a tree so enormous that it was impossible to guess its age.

They had black bodies, countless legs, and stiff hair covering them. The Beast Miao King discovered them and muttered like he was groaning.

“…Thousand-Year Spider.”

The monster of the Poisonblood Grounds had appeared.

[2828] A zhang is ten cheok, approximately 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

Chapter 638

Spiders?

I'd seen more than enough of them in my life. Hope Goshiwon[2829] had survived the war-torn Great Cataclysm, and all kinds of bugs had infested the place. Spiders were among its most regular guests.

Jinho hyung[2830] once said, "Could the landlord of this building be Fabre, by any chance?"

There were enough insects in that building to make you believe an entomologist who'd been dead for nearly two hundred years had come back to life.

But someone once said humans were creatures of adaptation.

At first, I couldn't stand the spiders appearing at all hours. Before a year had passed, I'd grown used to them. A few years later, I could even tell one species from another.

"Hyung[2831], say hello. This one's a ghost spider. The one next to it is a Joro spider."

"Forget saying hello. I get it, so move them away from me."

"And this one's a Brazilian wandering spider."

"I said move it—wait, why the hell is a Brazilian wandering spider wandering around Hope Goshiwon[2832]? How does that make any sense?"

"Why wouldn't it? I fought a goblin yesterday."

"Ah."

"And this one's a tarantula. Must be new here."

"Is this a nightmare? Why on earth is there a tarantula…?"

What a mysterious goshiwon[2833] ecosystem. I'd spent the flower of my youth there among countless spiders. Eventually, we'd been practically neighbors.

But I could say one thing for certain: I'd never seen a spider as hideous or enormous as the one that had just appeared before me.

"…Thousand-Year Spider?"

I'd never heard the name the Beast Miao King had just uttered. And the creature itself was on another level from a tarantula or a Brazilian wandering spider.

What the hell is that…?

If someone asked whether I'd ever seen a spider bigger than a bear, I'd nod without hesitation.

[2829] A *goshiwon* is an inexpensive Korean housing arrangement consisting of very small rooms with shared facilities.

[2830] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[2831] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

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[2833] A *goshiwon* is an inexpensive Korean housing arrangement consisting of very small rooms with shared facilities.

I was looking at one with my own two eyes.

Five of them, in fact.

Skritch, skritch!

Their movements were ghostlike. Every time their eight stiff, hair-covered legs moved, their enormous bodies slid along the trunks of the great trees.

The moment our rapidly approaching figures appeared in the monsters' eyes, large and small, the Beast Miao King shouted like a thunderclap.

"They're coming!"

And then—

Shhhhhaaa!

Pale, viscous slime poured down from above, covering a radius of ten or so zhang.[2834]

Thanks to the Beast Miao King's warning, I barely escaped the attack's range. I stared at the sight before me, eyes wide.

Hissss!

The ground, the rocks, the grass—even the unidentified Bai warrior's corpse we'd had to leave behind.

Everything the slime touched was melting with a foul stench, as though someone had poured acid over it.

Acid?

If I hadn't dodged without knowing what it was, or if even a little had touched me, the slime might have melted part of my body on the spot.

Just looking at it sent a chill down my spine. But I couldn't afford to stand there in shock.

Skritch, skritch!

Among the thick grass. Beyond the dense mist. On the great tree that blotted out the sky.

Five venomous spiders, each bigger than a bear and hideous beyond description, were closing in from every direction.

"…Are they surrounding us?"

The Beast Miao King raised his internal energy as he answered my incredulous mutter.

"Among the countless venomous beasts of Nanman, the Thousand-Year Spider is called a king. More than being ferocious, it is a cunning creature. There is even a record of a thousand warriors once trying to exterminate one, only for it to kill half of them over ten days and nights before vanishing."

"All that, from a spider? No, wait. If they've been around for a thousand years, I guess that makes sense."

[2834] In this Chinese setting, one *zhang* is a traditional unit of length of about 3.33 m (10.9 ft).

“They are called Thousand-Year Spiders because they can live that long. No one knows how old these particular creatures are. This may be the first time several have appeared at once, too.”

Nanman was home to countless venomous beasts, and five of the monsters called kings had appeared at once.

I looked at the slime that was still melting everything around us and muttered inwardly.

Damn it. We walked right into this.

I thought I understood why we hadn’t found the rest of the Nanman warriors’ bodies—or any sign of the beasts they’d commanded.

After filling their bellies to some degree through hunting, they must have carried the corpses deeper into the Poisonblood Grounds to stockpile food.

Wrapped tight in webs, like that Bai warrior.

They were certainly planning to hunt us the same way.

But…

That’s what you think.

As the creatures closed in with a skin-crawling rustle, I stretched my empty hand into the air.

Open Inventory. Summon.

Ding.

At my command, the boundless warehouse opened its doors. Of all the weapons I’d collected for emergencies, one spear radiating pure white light settled into my hand.

“Did I just see something wrong…?”

“You did. It’s a three-section folding spear, so I usually keep it in my sleeve.”

Leaving the Beast Miao King staring in disbelief, I sent internal energy into White Flame’s lowered spearhead.

Fwoooosh.

Flames of tangible qi bloomed over its edge, which radiated a chilling sharpness.

As the blue flames kindled by Scorching Yang Qi flickered, the dense Poison Mist surrounding us and the five Thousand-Year Spiders that had marked out positions around us and were slowly tightening their noose both flinched as though they had been burned.

Hissss.

Their cries and movements had turned wary. Their beetle-black eyes, some large and some small, darted in every direction.

But it was too late to retreat.

For them. For us.

The die had been cast. One side would live, and the other would die.

And today, we wouldn't be the ones getting hunted.

"What are you waiting for?" I leveled the blue-flamed spearhead at them. "Get over here already."

That was the signal.

Shhhhhaaa!

Pale slime came pouring at us from the front, the back, both sides, and overhead. The Beast Miao King and I shot forward to meet it.

Whoooosh!

Wind rushed over my body. The poison that had seeped in through my skin and airways ebbed away, while the flames surging around the silver spearhead burned higher.

Now.

Fwoosh! Kwoooong!

One swing.

I swept the spear around me in a single horizontal strike, and the slime pouring in from every direction evaporated as it met the flames.

And before that, the Beast Miao King's fist had already shot through the air.

Boom! Hissss!

The slime burst outward with a tremendous explosion, raining acid over several dozen zhang.[2835]

But neither of us had lost so much as a hair. We pressed on, leaving everything that was melting behind us.

Whoooosh!

The Beast Miao King went for the Thousand-Year Spider blocking the way ahead. I went for another clinging to the great tree above.

We hadn't made a plan, but one glance in passing was enough to tell us what the other intended.

Grab.

Just as I kicked off into the air, a large palm caught the tip of my foot.

Muscles that belied the Beast Miao King's eighty-plus years rippled through his arm. With a thunderous shout, he drove my foot upward with the force of a shot put.

"Go!"

Whoooosh!

Weightlessness swept through me.

[2835] In this Chinese setting, one *zhang* is a traditional unit of length of about 3.33 m (10.9 ft).

I hurtled upward, faster and harder than I could have managed with ordinary Stepping on Empty Air. In an instant, I was right in front of the eight-legged monster's face.

—…!

A multitude of emotions could be read in its many eyes, both large and small.

The Thousand-Year Spider looked almost human in its shock as I brought the spearhead down.

Swish! Slash!

A streak of flame cut through the air. Sticky blood sprayed.

The spider sacrificed three of its eight legs, each harder than steel, to survive the blow. It hastily spat slime at me.

Splatter! Hissss!

My quick movements and the Scorching Yang Qi that countered its poison helped me avoid the spray, but I'd been too close. Even what brushed my skin and clothes brought a searing pain.

Rather than groan, I drove my spear into its enormous body as it tried to escape.

Crack! Thrust!

Unlike insects, spiders are arthropods with thin exoskeletons. Their bodies aren't especially hard.

Even a Thousand-Year Spider, king of the venomous beasts, couldn't withstand Force.

"Fuck, you think I've only killed one or two spiders? If you'd lived in Hope Goshiwon[2836], your whole extended family—in-laws and eighth cousins included—would've died by my hand."

—Kiiiiiieet!

Its enormous body writhed as it shrieked.

I dodged another blast of slime, then caught the leg sweeping toward my side and tore it off with my bare hand.

Crack!

—Kieeeet!

Once, maybe. I wasn't getting caught by the same move twice.

The Thousand-Year Spider was convulsing now, not merely struggling. I drove the spearhead into its head.

Thrust!

Its flailing legs went limp. Its enormous body stiffened.

A notification sounded, confirming what I'd suspected.

Ding.

[2836] A *goshiwon* is an inexpensive Korean housing arrangement consisting of very small rooms with shared facilities.

SYSTEM

- **Defeated Lv. 117 Thousand-Year Spider!**
- **Gained a substantial amount of EXP and Fame!**
- **The Thousand-Year Spider is a special existence among the countless venomous beasts. An additional Reward will be granted!**
- **Achieved the rare Achievement Indiscriminate Hunting Bug!**
- **When facing insect-form enemies in the future, you will gain additional stats!**

The System notifications poured in as though they'd been waiting. But I had no time to read every line of the holographic window.

Below the great tree I stood on, the Beast Miao King was fighting for his life against several spiders at once.

Hissss!

"You bastards! Even tearing you to pieces wouldn't be enough! How dare you do this to my hair!"

"…"

His hair. He was worried about his hair at a time like this.

Half his clothes had melted away, exposing patches of skin, and the slime had eaten through almost all of his once-thick hair.

Even so, true to his title as one of the Ten Kings, he had already killed one and was fighting three at once.

Wham!

Correction. Two.

The moment the Beast Miao King's fist, thrown with a savage aura, smashed one of the Thousand-Year Spiders apart, I kicked off the great tree and plunged toward the ground like a bolt of lightning.

Whooosh! Crack!

My spearhead sank into a Thousand-Year Spider's body as though it were tofu. Then the powerful Scorching Yang Qi I'd drawn from my dantian surged inside it.

Fwoosh. Boom!

Its enormous body exploded into pieces. A torrent of bodily fluid sprayed out and evaporated. Only a new System notification remained above the unrecognizable corpse.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Defeated Lv. 109 Thousand-Year Spider!
Gained a substantial amount of EXP and Fame!
You have gained bonus EXP for defeating another extremely rare creature!
Level Up!

Fwoooosh.

Invisible healing light swept through me.

The skin melted by the slime and the internal energy I had expended were restored, while the flames on the spearhead, which had been slowly dying down, suddenly blazed as fiercely as though they had never weakened.

Fwoosh.

—Sssssss…

The last Thousand-Year Spider stared fearfully at the blue flames in the darkness. Then it fled.

Pat-pat-pat!

All eight legs kicked off the ground at once. Its huge body leaped into the air, stepped on something invisible, and settled lightly onto it.

That was when I caught sight of something glinting beyond the flames lighting up the darkness.

A spiderweb?

The thought flashed through my mind as the Beast Miao King and I raced after the fleeing spider.

Chapter 639

When I thought about it, it made sense.

No matter how extraordinary a venomous beast a Thousand-Year Spider was, it was still a spider. Webs covered the Poisonblood Grounds, which might as well have been its home. The last survivor of the five Thousand-Year Spider siblings had lost all will to fight and was fleeing along them.

What I hadn't expected was…

Thump! Shhhhk!

…how fast that enormous spider could run.

…What the hell? How is it that fast?

Maybe it was moving so quickly because it was fleeing for its life. Or maybe it had laid webs everywhere for just such an emergency. Either way, we could barely close the distance. It raced between the great trees and the open air dozens of zhang[2837] above us, with no obvious way for us to catch it.

No wonder Spider-Man's so fast…

I was using my movement technique when an inexplicable chill swept through me. I ducked on instinct.

Slice!

With a sharp cutting sound, a handful of hair drifted through the air. A web had narrowly missed my head. Tough and elastic as steel wire, it had become razor-sharp at that speed.

"Great Hero Yayul!"

I shouted a warning as soon as I realized what had happened, but the Beast Miao King was bigger than me and moved more roughly. He reacted a little too late.

Slice!

What was that, a razor commercial?

The top of his head had been shaved clean instead of his flesh and bone. He answered me with a look of utter misery.

"…Why did you call me?"

"…No reason. Just felt like it."

The thick hair that had streamed behind him like a lion's mane was gone. Between the Thousand-Year Spiders' barrages of acid-laden phlegm and this web, the crown of his head had been stripped bare. It gleamed like an octopus that had just come ashore.

Is this a battle between Doctor Octopus and Spider-Man?

The good and evil sides seemed to be reversed, but still. Watching a superhero movie play out right in front of me made my heart swell.

[2837] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese measure of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

The Octopus Miao King, whose hair was looking considerably less impressive, was not enjoying himself. His fury reached the heavens.

“You bastard! How dare you!”

His hair wasn’t the only reason, of course. The warriors might have belonged to different tribes, but hundreds of them—people who were practically his own—had died overnight. Savage energy spilled from his bloodshot eyes.

Kra-boom!

The Beast Miao King stamped his foot. The ground, sodden with poison and moisture, caved in beneath him like a sinkhole. Using the tremendous force of the rebound, he leaped high and threw a punch.

Whoooom! Bang!

Compressed air burst outward. The wind rippled.

Fist Energy tore through the air, severing webs hidden in the darkness as it shot toward the Thousand-Year Spider.

Shreeeek! Shhk!

But the blow missed. The spider narrowly escaped death and let out a chilling cry.

—Sssssisssss!

It was no ordinary cry. The strange noise burrowed into my ears like Sound Transmission and spread through the air. My sharpened senses picked up movement everywhere.

This is…

Rustle.

Amid the Poison Mist that had turned the Poisonblood Grounds into a land of death, the blackened grass stirred. Things emerged from between ancient trees, and I remembered a phrase I had briefly forgotten.

King of the venomous beasts.

It described the Thousand-Year Spider perfectly.

Venomous beasts had been crouching throughout the Poisonblood Grounds, waiting for orders. Now they answered their king’s call, gathering in a vast army that blocked our way.

Slither. Ssssss!

Snakes and centipedes as long and enormous as whips. Spiders and toads the size of human heads. Hundreds of bees pouring out from somewhere among the leaves of the great trees.

Hideous venomous beasts of kinds I couldn’t identify—and didn’t want to—converged. In the blink of an eye, dozens became hundreds, and hundreds became thousands. Together, they formed a wall.

Kraaaaa!

They blocked the only path through the Poisonblood Grounds, then surged toward us in a massive triangular wave.

Above them, the Thousand-Year Spider stood on a web much lower than before and looked down at us. It had stopped running. Now it gazed down like a king.

“Fucking bastard,” I muttered. “Now you want to look cool?”

This must have been its plan from the start.

Nanman really was a goddamn place. Why were its beasts and spiders so cunning?

I had entered the Poisonblood Grounds following the Black Tiger known as Ailao Mountain’s Wraith. The Thousand-Year Spider we encountered there had finally summoned all its guards once it reached a battlefield favorable to itself.

Judging by everything I had seen firsthand, its intelligence was in no way inferior to an ordinary human’s.

Compared to a certain glutton, it’s Einstein.

Taishan came to mind. I turned to the Beast Miao King.

Even he, after a lifetime in Nanman, seemed never to have seen anything like this. He let out a low groan. When our eyes met, his expression hardened.

“There’s no need to be afraid. Neither of us will die here.”

Afraid?

I gave a quiet laugh instead of answering. I couldn’t think of a word that was at once so close to me and so far away.

I’d always thought of myself as a coward, yet I’d never once backed down when faced with death.

At first, I became a Hunter because I wasn’t afraid. Later, I learned martial arts because I was.

Strange. I fought with everything I had because I was afraid of dying, but I kept walking into battlefields where I could die at any moment.

Still… today, at least, I didn’t think I would die.

Kraaaaaaaaa!

I watched the wave of venomous beasts roll closer, then spoke.

“When those things are gone, kill it immediately. No—just hurt it enough to leave it barely breathing.”

“What?”

“Remember, you can’t hesitate. We have to get it now, while it’s let its guard down and come lower.”

“What are you—”

Now.

Instead of answering, I stepped lightly against the ground. Internal energy was already surging from my dantian toward my toes.

Slither. Boom!

Compression. Then explosion.

The internal energy that burst from a single point—the tip of my toe—gave my entire body the speed of a beam of light. At the same time, a fierce gale wrapped around me and scattered the deep green Poison Mist.

Beyond it waited a colossal wall of thousands of venomous beasts.

Kraaaaaa!

A thick shadow fell over my head. The already dark Poisonblood Grounds plunged into complete darkness.

Then brilliant light burst from the blade of White Flame, the spear in my hand.

Vooooom.

With a hum like a swarm of bees, flames bluer than the sky took hold. Three jiazi's[2838] worth of powerful Scorching Yang Qi drew together, linked and coalesced into a still greater hellfire.

And at the end of it all—

One Annihilation.

Ruuuumble!

A flash tore through the darkness. A roar shook earth and sky.

Since childhood, Beast Miao King Yayul Cheok had thought of himself as a wild man.

He was rough and unrefined, with no use for etiquette or elegant manners. But perhaps it was true that a position shaped the person.

As the years went by, he found himself responsible for leading others. People began following him, though he couldn't see what there was in him worth following. Eventually he became Great Chieftain of the Bai people. Then one day he looked around and found himself Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace.

How did that happen?

He had no idea. All he'd done his entire life was train in martial arts.

But the water had been spilled long ago. There was no turning back and no gathering it up again, so he did his best to fulfill his duties as Palace Lord.

He stopped beating people up. He even cut back on the swearing that had once come as naturally as breathing.

Slapping a tribal chieftain who couldn't understand a damn thing he was told might bring him peace of mind. But if he slapped the man hard enough to deafen him permanently, that chieftain would rebel against the Nanman Beast Palace.

[2838] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi are 180 years.

Years as Palace Lord had made the Beast Miao King much tamer. Even so, at the sight before him, his lips began moving of their own accord.

"Uh… what the fuck is that? Uh…"

Ruuuumble!

Everything broke apart and melted.

The wave of thousands of venomous beasts was shattering before his eyes.

The two-headed horn snakes that hunted bears whenever they grew bored. The black frogs whose poison could kill a hundred bulls with a single drop. The golden bees said to strip a tiger to its bones in half a gak.[2839]

Fwoosh! Kraaaaaa!

Thousands of venomous beasts, every bit as powerful as they were hideous, turned to ash in the blue flames and the thunderous roar that lit the darkness.

…This is insane.

Not since the Great Faction War, more than fifty years ago, had he seen anything so astonishing.

Even the final ultimate technique unleashed by the Demonic Cult's Sword Demon just before his death could not compare with the sight before him. And even Fire King Jeok Cheongang, who had easily dodged the Sword Demon's final strike and methodically trampled him until he was on the verge of death, had never displayed this level of destructive power.

Nor, of course, had the man thinking it. Not even Beast Miao King Yayul Cheok himself.

How is this possible?

Unable to hide his shock and confusion, the Beast Miao King stared at the back of the young man standing tall before the blazing hellfire.

Then a single sentence suddenly flashed through his mind.

When those things are gone, kill it immediately. No—just hurt it enough to leave it barely breathing.

"…!"

At first, he had wondered what kind of nonsense the young man was spouting. Now that nonsense had become reality.

The Beast Miao King knew what he had to do.

Boom!

He shot toward the sky with a thunderous roar. He was half a beat late, but so was the Thousand-Year Spider, caught in a situation it could never have predicted.

—S-Siss?

Its many eyes, large and small, darted in different directions. The moment they found the Beast Miao King, they froze.

[2839] A *gak* is a traditional unit of time, roughly seven and a half minutes.

His few remaining hairs streamed behind him as he flew upward. A cold smile touched his lips.

“I’ve finally caught you. You piece of shit. I’ll tear you apart.”

—…!

The Thousand-Year Spider had made two fatal mistakes.

First, it had underestimated the young human’s strength.

Second, it had killed the old human’s tribespeople and shaved off the thick hair he had always been proud of.

Splaaash!

Its last desperate spray of slime cut through empty air. The Beast Miao King caught one of its legs.

Crack!

—Siiiiiiit!

The leg tore free. Screaming in pain, the Thousand-Year Spider plummeted toward the ground.

Chapter 640

One Annihilation was a technique that didn't merely destroy its target. It erased it.

It drew out all my power in an instant, producing several times my usual strength. The greater my martial attainment, the more powerful One Annihilation became.

But it had one fatal drawback…

Beep. Beep. Beep-beep-beep!

SYSTEM

You have exhausted all your power!
Warning! Warning! The effects of overusing your abilities will rebound on you in full!
Status abnormality Internal Injury applied!
Status abnormality Exhaustion applied!
Status abnormality Anemia applied!
Status abnormality Paralyzed applied!
Due to the stacked status abnormalities, all stats temporarily decrease by 100!

As One Annihilation grew more powerful, its aftereffects grew more severe.

…Ah. Damn it.

My entire body trembled as though I'd been electrocuted. My once-clear vision blurred like a screen full of static.

Turning thousands of venomous beasts to ash had come at a steep price.

Still, I thought I'd at least level up once.

The higher my Level rose, the less EXP I gained.

Back when I had been a low-level nobody who could barely stand up to a single Peak Master, leveling up could cover for that weakness to some extent. But now that my vessel had grown larger, I needed far more EXP to fill it, and even leveling up had become difficult.

"…Hng."

Internal Injury and Exhaustion weren't enough. I had Anemia and paralysis, too. It was a miracle I hadn't passed out.

I staggered, my vision swimming, and barely managed to drive White Flame into the ground.

Thud!

Leaning on my spear in this sorry state, I wished Jeok Cheongang had taught me the Dance of the Fire God and Demon. Not that there was any point begging him. I knew what he'd say.

The Dance of the Fire God and Demon? Is dying young your life's ambition?

He said it was too dangerous, but really, the difference would be no greater than the one between a pistol and an automatic rifle.

To be honest, at this rate, I felt like I might die far from home using One Annihilation before then.

Not that I had the slightest intention of dying in a horrible place like this.

That's why I took out insurance.

Just as I thought that, the insurance agent noticed his client's accident and dropped out of the sky.

Whoooosh. Boom!

The heavily built old man landed on the Thousand-Year Spider, using its enormous, barely living, convulsing body as a cushion.

The Beast Miao King, his face flushed, spread both arms toward me.

"Uh, that's really crossing the line—"

Grab! Crack!

"What an incredible bastard!"

"Argh! Aaaagh!"

"How did you do that? Was it the Fire Gate Clan's unique martial art? Or the final ultimate technique Old Man Jeok learned?"

Whap! Whap!

"Uuuugh!"

"What a monster! I couldn't believe it even while watching!"

"Aaaaaagh! You crazy bastard!"

"What? Crazy bastard? Yes! That's exactly what you are—a madman born of the Central Plains!"

I nearly died far from home. I wasn't joking.

When the madman born of Nanman finally let go of me, a mournful notification sounded in my ear.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Status abnormality Mild Ligament Tear applied!
Strength decreases by 20 until recovery!
Agility decreases by 20 until recovery!

"…"

This was why Doctor Octopus[2840] was a villain.

[2840] Doctor Octopus is a Marvel Comics villain known for his mechanical tentacle arms.

I didn't have the strength to say anything else. Gasping through the pain, I glared at the Beast Miao King and barely managed to speak.

"Spider. Spider."

"Spider? Oh, the Thousand-Year Spider?"

"Quick. Hurry."

At my pitiful gestures, the Beast Miao King nodded in admiration.

"I wondered if that was what you meant, but are you planning to use the Thousand-Year Spider to figure out the Poisonblood Grounds? You really are something."

"Ah, please."

"Ha, all right. Just as you asked, I brought it here alive and unharmed—"

Before he could spout any more nonsense, I squeezed out what little strength I had left.

"Gnnngh!"

I wrenched White Flame free and drove it straight into the Thousand-Year Spider's head, like a patient collecting a random insurance payout.

Thud!

—Ssssit! Kieeeek!

The monster gave a brief death cry. Then heavenly bells rang from somewhere.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

You defeated Level 119 Thousand-Year Spider!
Additional EXP has been awarded for defeating a rare entity!
Level Up!
The damaged body has been substantially restored!
All status abnormalities have been removed!
Warning! Your physical condition is not yet perfect! A little treatment and rest are required!

Ah, this was why I took out insurance.

If the EXP from one venomous beast was an ant's tear, the Thousand-Year Spider was a downpour from heaven.

Add its EXP to what I'd earned killing thousands of venomous beasts at once, and life immediately surged back into my dying body.

"Buuuurp."

Last hit. Sweet.

As the ancient sages said, one Level Up made the five loaves and two fish[2841] look like nothing.

I couldn't tell you which sage said it, but someone did. It was true, too.

Whew. I almost died.

Having barely made it back from the nursing home's doorstep, I rubbed my stomach, feeling a satisfying fullness spread through my body.

Then I looked up and met the eyes of someone staring at me with a distinctly unimpressed expression.

"Why?"

"…"

"What is it?"

"…"

After a moment, the Beast Miao King spoke, his expression gone cold.

"Why did you tell me to keep it alive if you were going to do that?"

Why else? To get the EXP, obviously.

But years of working for a shitty small Guild had given me something I had never possessed before: social awareness and people skills.

I answered with a mournful, rigid expression.

"I wanted to take revenge with my own hands."

"What?"

"For the Nanman warriors who died at the hands… no, the slime and webs of those bastards. Tearing them apart wouldn't have been enough."

"…!"

The Beast Miao King's eyes widened, emotion stirring in them. He stared at me, his gaze trembling, then spoke in a choked voice.

"I… don't know what to say."

"Shh. Don't say anything. I already know."

"You… you little bastard!"

What a romantic moment… Like hell. Fuck off. I was going to gag.

But one thing was certain: the Beast Miao King couldn't hide how moved he was.

Well, the result's good. That's what matters, right?

I didn't need to feel guilty. I genuinely mourned the Nanman warriors, and I genuinely needed the EXP to recover.

More importantly, my quick excuse had made things better.

If word of this gets around Nanman, maybe the odds of the Nanman Beast Palace joining the Murim Alliance will go up ten percent.

[2841] The five loaves and two fish refer to a biblical account in which a small amount of food feeds a multitude.

Even so, a weight remained in my chest.

I felt guilty because I hadn't been able to prevent hundreds of people from being massacred less than two shichen[2842] away.

…Damn it.

A bitter taste filled my mouth.

Even now, countless people were probably dying across both the modern world and Murim. Some in traffic accidents. Some at the hands of monsters.

A martial artist might get into a quarrel at an inn, draw a sword, and die on the spot. Somewhere, a nameless hero might lose their life fighting an evildoer.

I knew I couldn't save them all.

But I was human, and I hated seeing other people die.

And I felt regret, too. Regret that if I had been there, perhaps I could have saved innocent people.

Great power comes with great responsibility.

At some point, that line from a superhero movie had become a boulder weighing on my body and mind.

It weighed on me even while I circulated my qi, when I needed to give it my full concentration.

Maybe this is a Heart Demon,[2843] too.

I sighed softly, shook my head, and started walking again, leaving the Thousand-Year Spider's corpse behind.

We headed deeper into the hidden reaches of the Poisonblood Grounds.

Splash. Splash.

The Beast Miao King and I watched our steps more carefully now. Killing five Thousand-Year Spiders and an enormous number of venomous beasts had left the area quiet, but it was too soon to let our guard down.

That bastard is the biggest problem of all.

Ailao Mountain's Wraith.

The Black Tiger fit the name the System had given it perfectly. It was the one thing we had to watch for above all else.

Its enormous body moved like the wind. The powerful, eerie qi I'd sensed from it, however briefly, proved it was far beyond any ordinary spiritual creature or venomous beast.

—Where do you think it is now?

It was useful having someone beside me who was thinking the same thing. I moved my lips in answer to the Beast Miao King's Sound Transmission.

[2842] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

[2843] In martial-arts fiction, a Heart Demon is a psychological obstacle that can hinder a person's cultivation.

—Who knows? But I'm sure it's still in the Poisonblood Grounds.

—That's what I don't understand. Why lure us all this way and then fail to appear? Fifteen minutes ago, we would have been at a clear disadvantage.

He was right.

Despite their reputation, the five Thousand-Year Spiders had been easier to handle than I'd expected, and so had the thousands of venomous beasts. But if Ailao Mountain's Wraith had joined them, things would have been different.

If it had joined the fight from the beginning, we could probably have put up a decent fight. But if it had appeared right after I used One Annihilation…

Even if we'd done everything right, it would have been a brutal fight.

Its teeth could withstand Force. It was unbelievably fast, and, true to its name, its presence was as impossible to sense as a wraith's.

One of us might have died. Or left a limb behind.

At worst, we'd both be dead.

But why? Why didn't it appear even under those circumstances?

I didn't know. Only two remotely plausible explanations came to mind.

First, a classic island-nation plot twist:[2844]

Heh heh. The Thousand-Year Spider is merely the weakest of our Four Great Venomous Beasts.

And second:

Ailao Mountain's Wraith has no intention of hurting us.

I took a few cautious steps and discarded the second theory. However I looked at it, it seemed too unlikely.

Before I could think any further, the Beast Miao King, who had been following behind and watching our flanks and rear, put his broad hand on my shoulder.

Tap.

Oh, shit.

That scared the hell out of me. My heart nearly fell out of my chest.

I steadied myself and turned to look where his finger was pointing.

Beyond the Poison Mist, growing thicker with every step, and the dark jungle crowding in on all sides, a faint, unfamiliar light shone through.

Could it be?

We didn't need to say anything. My instincts had reached the answer before my thoughts had.

Rustle. Crackle.

We pushed through grass that carried a faint trace of poison and came to the source of the light.

[2844] "Island nation" alludes to Japan; the line parodies a villain-reveal trope in Japanese manga and anime.

At last, we saw what lay before us. Both of us stopped, mouths hanging open.

“This is…!”

A vast swamp lay under the faint moonlight.

Waiting there were countless shapes hanging, each bound tight in transparent spiderwebs—and white eggs.

Chapter 641

Sometimes, the mere sight of something sends a chill down your spine and makes your hair stand on end.

Like everything in front of me now.

Fwoosh.

Faint moonlight spilled through the swaying leaves, as mysterious as a scene from a myth. But it wasn't shining on a peaceful blue lake.

What is this…?

A dark, desolate swamp. Hundreds of large shapes hung there, wrapped in layer upon layer of spiderwebs like silkworm cocoons. Around them were white eggs, smaller but several times more numerous.

What the hell are they?

An ominous question weighed on me, one I felt I shouldn't learn the answer to.

Even so, I'd instinctively reached out. My hand was already touching the nearest cocoon.

Tap.

An unpleasant sensation ran through my fingertip. At the same moment, a System notification sounded in my ear.

Beep. Ding.

SYSTEM

You have been Poisoned by the Thousand-Year Spider's Paralysis Poison!

If you are not detoxified quickly, you may enter Full-Body Paralysis and Unconsciousness!

The potential effect of the Myriad-Poison Ring has been activated!

All status abnormalities related to Poison have been removed!

My fingertip went numb for a moment, then felt cool and clear again.

The Myriad-Poison Ring was a divine artifact capable of absorbing even Formless Ultimate Poison. However unusual a venomous beast the Thousand-Year Spider might be, its poison couldn't harm me.

If this is a Thousand-Year Spider's web…

A possibility struck me. I tightened my grip and tore the webbing apart.

Crack. Riiiip.

Hundreds of layers of webbing gave way under my grip. When the shape concealed inside was revealed, the Beast Miao King, who had been watching from beside me, muttered like he was groaning.

“A person?”

He was right.

The man’s face was as white as paper, and his body lay perfectly still. The Beast Miao King checked the unknown man’s faint pulse and breathed a sigh of relief.

“Thank goodness. He’s still alive.”

I had expected as much. According to what the System had told me earlier, the Thousand-Year Spider’s webs did not contain poison powerful enough to kill their victims.

The reason was probably…

To keep them fresh. So the spiders can eat whenever they want.

Now I understood why the sight of this place had made my hair stand on end.

A slaughterhouse.

Before it was the Thousand-Year Spiders’ home, this swamp was a slaughterhouse and an enormous food store.

Only then did I detect the heavy smell of blood beneath the stench coming from all around us.

“Spider bastards. They’ve sure been stuffing their faces for a long time.”

Hundreds. No, perhaps thousands.

If the Nanman Beast Palace’s records were right and the Five Poisons Sect had created the Poisonblood Grounds, there was no telling how many people had died here over the years.

Ironically, the spiders’ habit meant we could save many of their captives today.

It did seem strange. More warriors had disappeared than died.

About three hundred elite warriors had been stationed at Ailao Mountain. The five Thousand-Year Spiders had killed roughly a hundred on the spot, eaten their fill, then dragged the rest into the Poisonblood Grounds. Before long, they would have eaten those warriors one by one.

Instead, we’d found them.

“Would you look at these goddamn bastards! They deserve to die!”

The Beast Miao King’s eyes were red with fury. I tried to calm him down.

“Uh, sorry to interrupt, but you already killed them.”

“Tearing them to pieces wouldn’t be enough!”

“Uh…”

Well, I couldn’t argue with that. But for now, we needed to deal with the situation, not dwell on our anger.

After calming down a little, the Beast Miao King looked around with a devastated expression.

“To think they dared to do something like this.”

“You said there hadn’t been any major losses before now, didn’t you?”

“It’s true. At least during my time as Palace Lord, we’ve had no trouble like this.”

“Strange, then. Five Thousand-Year Spiders suddenly show up and attack your warriors at a time like this.”

He was silent for a moment at my pointed words. Then he said, “Dark Heaven… Do you think this was their doing?”

I nodded without hesitation.

“I don’t know if they were directly involved, but I’d bet they had a hand in it. There’s nothing strange about Thousand-Year Spiders attacking people. The timing, though? Of course I suspect Dark Heaven.”

“But if they are behind this, they could have waited until after you left. Doing it on the final day of the Tribal Grand Council only hurts their cause.”

“Well…”

My voice trailed off. His point was sharper than I’d expected, and I couldn’t easily dismiss it.

He’s right. If I were the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—that bitch—I wouldn’t have bothered.

Even without any interference, it was practically certain that the Nanman Beast Palace’s entry into the Murim Alliance would fall through. Dark Heaven had no reason to stir up Nanman for nothing.

So why?

Nothing about it made sense. Ailao Mountain’s Wraith had appeared out of nowhere and still hadn’t shown itself. Five Thousand-Year Spiders had suddenly begun a massacre. And there was the question of whether they were connected to Dark Heaven.

I was still frowning over it when the Beast Miao King’s voice brought me back.

“Right now, the problem is moving these people. It’s a blessing they’re alive, but getting them out of the Poisonblood Grounds is another matter.”

I set those thoughts aside. “If you ask me, we should leave the others as they are.”

“Leave them? Here?”

“…Do I look insane? Of course we’re taking them back to the Nanman Beast Palace. I told White Tiger to bring people here, so we should wait for them. Assuming he understood me.”

“You mean Muyaho. He’s cleverer than most people. I’m sure he understood.”

“…”

“What’s that look for?”

"Oh. Nothing."

I nearly burst out laughing.

Muyaho. The more I heard that name, the harder it was to get used to. I managed to straighten my face and went on.

"And we should leave the webs intact."

"Because of the poison."

"Yes."

Getting here had been difficult. Getting back would be far worse. We'd have to take some two hundred patients through the Poison Mist after they woke from several shichen[2845] of full-body paralysis and unconsciousness.

I'm not even sure how much the Myriad-Poison Ring can cover.

The Myriad-Poison Ring certainly possessed mysterious power, but I couldn't put two hundred lives through a fifty-fifty gacha[2846] roll just by trusting in this one item.

They were safer staying wrapped in the webs.

"At least the Poison Mist doesn't seem to affect them in there. Otherwise, they'd have died on the way here."

"True. Perhaps the Thousand-Year Spider's poison in the webs keeps other poisons out."

In a sense, it was poison countering poison. The webs had been coffins on the journey here. Now they could serve as cryogenic capsules, keeping the warriors safe from the Poison Mist.

Besides, even if I unwrapped and detoxified them one at a time, there was only so much I could do. Our conversations would probably go something like this:

All right, patient. Slowly open your eyes. Can you see the fingers I'm waving in front of you? If you can, tell me how many there are.

"Uhh… One. One."

Which finger?

"The middle one."

Right. It means fuck you.

"Huh? What are you talking about all of a sudden…?"

It was a simple test. Anyway, good. You can see and hear clearly now. Both your sight and hearing have recovered.

"Thank you. Thank you so much, Han Chinese sir."

Ha ha. Don't mention it. The paralysis should be gone now that you've been detoxified. Can you move your fingers?

"Of course. I can move them just fine."

[2845] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2846] Gacha refers to a game mechanic in which a random draw determines the reward.

Good. I have something for you to do with them. First, what's your name?

"Me? Jang Sam."

Excellent. Here's a dagger. Write what I dictate on this wooden tablet.

"Yes, all right."

Write exactly what I say. Jang Sam.

"Jang. Sam."

Lies here.

"Lies here. Wait, what?"

I didn't want to alarm you, but we have to go back the way we came. And we're out of poison-warding pearls. Oh, I'll be fine. I have the Myriad-Poison Ring.

"…!"

I'm 'invincible.' The Myriad-Poison Ring is a 'god.'

Hmm.

That would turn into a two-hundred-against-one battle to the death over the Myriad-Poison Ring.

Or two hundred against two. The Beast Miao King had a big, beautiful top-grade poison-warding pearl of his own.

"…Why are you looking at me like that?" he asked.

"It's nothing."

"Is it Dark Heaven?"

"No. Heaven as in the sky."

His expression hardened. "Are you actually insane…?"

If my department head had been here, he would have laughed. But it seemed the Palace Lord didn't get the joke.

The Beast Miao King looked me over with an expression like he was staring at a Thousand-Year Spider walking on two legs, then began gathering the warriors wrapped in webs into one place.

Slice. Slice.

Every time his straightened palm moved, the people hanging in midair were neatly stacked together.

There were two hundred of them—almost exactly the number of warriors who had gone missing from Ailao Mountain.

Wait. What about the ferocious beasts?

As I helped the Beast Miao King move the survivors, I remembered one of the questions I'd had while searching Ailao Mountain: the missing ferocious beasts were nowhere to be seen.

The Beast Miao King soon noticed it as well and wore a puzzled expression.

"That is strange. There is no sign of the ferocious beasts."

“Are they timid, by any chance? Do they tuck their tails and run when they meet strangers?”

“I’m asking because I’m curious, but do you perhaps not know what ‘ferocious beast’ means?”

Of course I did. *Ferocious. Beast.*

That was why it was strange. So many of them wouldn’t have abandoned their masters and run away.

And it’s not as if Thousand-Year Spiders are picky eaters.

I knew spiders. Hope Goshiwon, where I’d lived for nearly seven years, had more spiders than hope.[2847] I’d even grown fond enough of them to share my ramen.

Then where the hell did the beasts go?

We’d have to search more of the Poisonblood Grounds to find out, but I doubted Thousand-Year Spiders were meticulous enough to sort their food by type.

Just as the Beast Miao King and I were looking around in confusion—

Rustle.

A small sound came from more than ten zhang[2848] away. With it, I sensed a faint presence.

[2847] A goshiwon is an inexpensive housing arrangement of very small rooms, often with shared facilities.

[2848] A zhang is ten chi, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). More than ten zhang is over 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

Chapter 642

Rustle.

A faint noise came from the distance, followed by a presence closing in fast. I whipped White Flame toward it.

The Beast Miao King immediately drew up his internal energy. The same thought must have crossed his mind.

The Wraith of Ailao Mountain.

But we were both wrong. I caught a glimpse of white beyond the dark grass and lowered my spearhead with a sigh.

"Muyaho?"

- Grrr!

Rustle, rustle!

White Tiger came running like the wind, gave a short, powerful cry, and bounded happily toward me… only to run straight past and flop onto its back at the Beast Miao King's feet.

- Pant. Pant. Pant.

"Yes, yes. You managed to find your way here. What a clever little fellow."

At this point, maybe we should call it a silver retriever instead of a white tiger. Granted, it was the size of ten retrievers put together.

If he's back, then…

As if he'd read my mind, the Beast Miao King stroked White Tiger's belly while it showed off for him.

"Where are the others?"

- Grrrr.

White Tiger rose with a contented growl, then suddenly let out a mighty roar. It rang through the darkness and Poison Mist. Before long, torches flickered in the distance.

There were dozens of them, perhaps as many as a hundred.

And at their head were familiar faces.

"Palace Lord."

"Father! Are you all right?"

Baeksang and Yayul Mok approached with the Nanman Beast Palace warriors, their faces unusually grim. Behind them, the Fire Dragon Pavilion members came running toward me.

"Captaiiin!"

"Mujin, just in case this needs saying: if you throw yourself into my arms, you won't die a pleasant death."

"...Yes, sir."

That stopped Hyuk Mujin before he could charge into me like the heroine of a tragic romance. I shrugged at the other members as they opened their mouths.

"The story's long if I start from the beginning... Want to hear it here, or outside?"

I didn't need to wait for an answer.

If we'd been in a cozy café with sentimental pop music playing, maybe. But no one wanted a long story in the gloomy Poisonblood Grounds, with Poison Mist drifting around us.

The System, meanwhile, hadn't forgotten the Quest I'd briefly put out of my mind.

Ding.

SYSTEM

- **Quest: My Good Sir, Do Not Cross That Swamp has been successfully completed!**
- **Quest Reward will be granted!**
- **You have acquired a considerable amount of EXP and Fame!**
- **You have acquired 5 Top-Grade Poison-Warding Pearls!**
- **You have earned the very rare Achievement: How'd You Get Back?!**
- **You have acquired the rare Title: Poisonblood Grounds Pioneer!**

That night, the darkness over Nanman seemed unusually deep and long. But everything has a beginning and an end.

Deep in the night, while everyone slept, a hundred elite warriors hurried to Ailao Mountain. They returned to the Nanman Beast Palace near dawn, and plenty of people saw them arrive.

"Did you hear? Something huge happened last night."

"What happened?"

"Well, old man Mong, who lives near the West Gate of the Outer Palace, told me..."

"Gasp!"

"What? I haven't even started."

"He's still alive? I was sure he died last year."

"Ah, fuck."

By morning, the gist of the rumor was spreading fast.

Something major had happened somewhere in Nanman the night before. Baeksang, Great Chieftain of the Bai people, and Young Palace Lord Yayul Mok had

led a hundred elite warriors out of the Outer Palace. When they returned a few shichen[2849] later, the Beast Miao King and Jin Taekyung were at the head of the party.

The Nanman Beast Palace did not normally intervene by force in disputes between tribes. For the Palace Lord himself to have gone out meant it was a serious incident.

But the rumor didn't stop there.

"And the trouble was at Ailao Mountain, of all places."

"Ailao Mountain? *That* Ailao Mountain?"

"Is there another Ailao Mountain in Nanman? Yao merchants from a village a hundred li[2850] from the mountain told us at first light. They happened to see it while working late on their ledgers."

To the people of Nanman, the name Five Poisons Sect was a burden they could never cast off. Their ancestors had fought the sect, and only after countless sacrifices had they established the order and laws they lived by today.

And yet, of all places, the incident had occurred in Ailao Mountain, the Five Poisons Sect's former headquarters.

Ordinarily, it was a forbidden place they didn't even want to mention. Trouble there was another matter.

"What the hell? Go on. Hurry!"

Through markets lined with stalls, back alleys, and busy inns, the story passed from mouth to ear and from one mouth to the next.

The chieftains gathered for that day's Tribal Grand Council knew all about the commotion. They also knew the rumors circulating through the Outer and Inner Palaces were more accurate than anyone might have expected.

"The whole place is in an uproar. Everyone's heard."

"The bigger problem is that it isn't just a rumor. Isn't that right?"

They had gathered for the first time in a year, but there was no time to exchange pleasantries. Seated early in the Inner Palace's vast main hall, the chieftains continued their discussion with grave expressions.

"You all received word in advance, so you know this is no ordinary matter. Nearly a hundred elite warriors have already died at Ailao Mountain because of creatures that should have stayed in the Poisonblood Grounds."

"I heard Thousand-Year Spiders appeared. Frankly, I find that hard to believe. Five of them, no less."

"Hard to believe, but true. Their corpses are still there. Enraged by the deaths of the warriors stationed at Ailao Mountain, the Palace Lord pursued the creatures into the Poisonblood Grounds and hunted them down."

[2849] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[2850] Using the Chinese *li* of 500 meters (0.311 miles), a hundred li is about 50 kilometers (31 miles).

The middle-aged chieftain who had answered so readily added in a low voice, "That young Han Chinese man from the Murim Alliance was with him, too. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung."

Every chieftain in the hall governed some part of Nanman, large or small. Naturally, they knew of the young outsider. Their reactions varied.

"Oh."

"Hmm."

"Ahem."

One nodded with an exclamation of admiration. Another cleared his throat uneasily and stared at nothing.

But the mood had changed since a few days earlier. This time, no one called him a "damned Han Chinese bastard."

Even the chieftains who normally disliked Han Chinese people knew Jin Taekyung had played no small part in resolving the incident.

"Without him, it might not have ended so quickly. The Palace Lord went after those creatures in haste. Perhaps he might even have been hurt—"

Bang!

A sudden boom drowned out the rest.

Some thirty pairs of eyes turned to one chieftain. He had looked displeased ever since Jin Taekyung's name came up, and now he had slammed a hand on the stone table.

"I tried to hold my tongue, but I can't listen to this anymore. Watch what you say, Chief Jang. The Palace Lord is far stronger than you think. The same goes for everyone in Nanman. We don't need help from some weak Han Chinese bastard!"

The middle-aged chieftain frowned.

"What brave and prideful words. Truly moving. But didn't you hear that weak Han Chinese bastard dealt with two Thousand-Year Spiders and thousands of venomous beasts in the Poisonblood Grounds? That he is a renowned warrior of the Central Plains who inherited the Fire King's legacy?"

"Th-that…"

"And five years ago, who invaded our tribe's territory even after the Palace Lord personally mediated the dispute? Wasn't it you? Even if a venomous snake's bitten your mouth, speak straight. Your loyalty isn't to the Palace Lord. It's to Great Chieftain Baeksang. All of Nanman knows you're his loyal dog."

"What? Loyal dog? You son of a bitch!"

"Son of a bitch? You piece of poisonous refuse left behind by the Five Poisons Sect —how dare you…"

Bang!

The two chieftains sprang to their feet, snarling as if they were about to draw their swords on each other.

Rumble…

The enormous stone gate swung open. Three figures stepped into the hall.

Step. Step.

Footsteps echoed through the sudden quiet. The man in front stopped, and his voice came cold as ice.

“Looks like I interrupted your conversation.”

“…!”

“…!”

“Don’t mind me. Carry on.”

No one said a word.

As if nothing had happened, the shouting that had filled the hall only moments ago vanished in an instant, replaced by a heavy silence that pressed down on everyone. At the same time, the expressions of the two opposing chieftains split between joy and sorrow.

“Welcome, Great Chieftain Baeksang.”

Baeksang glanced at the groveling loyal dog, then fixed his eyes on the middle-aged chieftain.

“That was an interesting conversation. I’d like to hear the rest.”

“…”

“You’ve grown quiet since I last saw you, Chief Jang.”

Chief Jang bit his lip and lowered his head.

“I greet Great Chieftain Baeksang.”

Yohi, Great Chieftain of the Yao people, stood to Baeksang’s right. She gave a quiet laugh.

“We must be invisible. Don’t you think, big brother Heugung?”

“Hm? Oh. Yes, that won’t do. Failing to show proper courtesy with our lovely Yohi right here? No, that won’t do.”

Heugung had been grinning foolishly at Yohi. He put on a stern face, but Baeksang’s chilly glance made his plump body shrink back.

“S-sorry, Uncle Baek. But did I do something wrong…?”

“Oh, what could you have done wrong? Our kind, handsome big brother Heugung hasn’t done anything wrong. Has he?”

“R-right. Yohi’s right.”

Baeksang watched them in silence, clicked his tongue, and resumed walking.

The table was large enough to seat several dozen people. It had one head seat, and the three seats nearest it belonged to the great chieftains, second only to the Palace Lord.

Scrape. Clack.

Twenty-eight chieftains had arrived before them. With the three great chieftains now seated, thirty-one places had found their owners.

Baeksang had seen this arrangement year after year. Yet something felt wrong.

“Two seats are empty.”

At first, no one understood what he meant. Then Yohi spoke with laughter in her voice, and the chieftains’ puzzlement gave way.

“You’re right. How strange. Why are two seats empty?”

Only thirty-two seats were ever prepared for the Tribal Grand Council. That had been true a hundred years ago, and it was true now. Anyone who was not a chieftain—even the Young Palace Lord—had to stand in attendance.

There should have been only one empty seat left.

Today, there were two.

“Why would…”

And just as a puzzled murmur escaped someone’s lips—

Rumble…

The enormous stone gate moved again. Two figures appeared beyond it at last.

The moment Baeksang saw them, his eyes darkened.

Chapter 643

Rumble!

The stone gate descended behind me with a heavy rumble.

Inside the spacious main hall, illuminated by spreading lamplight, thirty-one pairs of eyes flew toward my face like arrows and lodged there amid a silence in which no one spoke.

What are you doing coming out of there?

That was the look they gave me. But it held more surprise than hostility toward a Han Chinese man, and several chieftains even looked pleased to see me.

Of course, there was one absolute exception.

“One of two things must be true. Either my eyes deceive me, or the rules of the Tribal Grand Council have changed without anyone—including me—knowing.”

The middle-aged man who broke the silence was Baeksang, the Great Chieftain of the Bai people. He continued in a cold voice.

“Explain why you’ve brought a mere Han Chinese man here. He is neither a chieftain nor a Nanman.”

Baeksang wasn’t asking the Beast Miao King, who had yet to arrive. He wasn’t asking me, either.

Yayul Mok stood to my right. He answered calmly.

“Because he has the right to be here.”

“The right.”

Baeksang repeated the words under his breath.

“That sounds like the rash judgment of a brat who isn’t even thirty.”

“It is also the judgment of someone else who has yet to arrive.”

“…!”

“My father. No—the Palace Lord said he has the right to attend the Tribal Grand Council.”

Baeksang’s eyes darkened. After a moment’s silence, he asked, “Why hasn’t the Palace Lord come?”

“He’ll be here soon. By then, there will be only one empty seat left.”

“Unacceptable.”

Baeksang tapped the table with a finger pierced by a nail.

“The Tribal Grand Council is a solemn gathering where the chieftains representing all of Nanman come together to exchange their views. If one is not a chieftain, no one may take a seat here except the Young Palace Lord. This man’s qualification is merely the will of the Palace Lord alone. We will not permit it.”

I watched for a moment, then muttered, “That’s funny. Isn’t that just your opinion?”

I was clearly talking to myself, but none of the chieftains gathered here were so lacking in martial arts that they couldn't hear me.

That went without saying for Baeksang, whose martial arts were particularly formidable.

He turned a cold gaze on me. "What did you say?"

"Oh, you heard me?"

"Did you think I wouldn't?"

"No. I said it so you would. Glad you caught that."

"…!"

I shrugged at his frozen expression.

"Since the subject has come up, let me say this. We may call ourselves 'we,' but isn't this ultimately just your personal opinion as well? You haven't even asked what the other chieftains think, yet you say you won't permit it. What exactly are we supposed to do with that?"

As my words continued to flow smoothly, I could feel an invisible stir spreading among the seated chieftains.

Baeksang was the Great Chieftain of the Bai people, the most powerful tribe in Nanman after the Miao people, as well as a Supreme Peak master who represented Nanman alongside the Beast Miao King.

I doubted anyone had ever dared speak to him so openly.

Anyone but me.

"When Great Hero Yayul sent me ahead, he told me this: 'Yayul Cheok, Great Chieftain of the Miao people, recognizes your right to attend. But Yayul Cheok, Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, cannot decide this alone. Gain the other chieftains' consent.'"

Nanman was hardly a welcoming place for outsiders. Even breathing here felt like a privilege. And the Tribal Grand Council, held once a year, was so rigid a needle couldn't slip through its rules.

If the Beast Miao King hadn't done me this favor, they'd have stopped me at the door.

His help had gotten me past those rules. Now I intended to claim a seat—by winning the other chieftains' support.

"So that's what I'd like to ask."

I met their eyes one by one.

"What do the rest of you think?"

Fwoosh.

A breeze from somewhere made the torches flicker. In their reddish light, some faces tightened with discomfort, others looked troubled, and more than I'd expected looked receptive.

Including the middle-aged chieftain who had just opened his mouth.

“Everyone here, including my Zang people, knows what happened at Ailao Mountain last night.”

From what I’d seen and heard in Nanman, the Zang people weren’t one of its four great tribes, but they had enough strength to stand just behind them.

The man who appeared to lead them continued slowly.

“An unexpected disaster cost us much blood. Swift action kept the loss from becoming greater. We owe that to our wise Palace Lord, Great Chieftain Yayul, and to a young Han Chinese man who helped him.”

His strong voice carried through the hall. He watched the other chieftains’ expressions shift, then turned to me with a faint smile.

“It’s late, but I want to thank you here. Because of your help, twenty-two brave, fine warriors of the Zang people are alive. One of them is my own kin.”

“Ah.”

Around two hundred warriors had been dragged into the Poisonblood Grounds. I hadn’t learned all their names or who they were.

I hadn’t known, and couldn’t have known. But what I’d done last night was coming back to me now as goodwill and gratitude.

“On behalf of the Zang people, I welcome Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung to the Tribal Grand Council.”

He finished with a respectful salute—not one from the land where he’d been born and raised, but a cupped-fist salute from the Central Plains.

And that was only the beginning.

Scrape. Scrape.

Unfamiliar chieftains rose one after another. Their faces and clothing differed, but they spoke with the same goodwill.

“We can’t accept a kindness and pretend it never happened. The Hui people support his attendance.”

“The Man people have no objection. I only wish to thank him for saving my good-for-nothing son.”

Each of them ruled a tribe, large or small.

But they were also heads of families. Fathers and mothers with children they loved.

One by one, they offered me their thanks with painfully awkward cupped-fist salutes. The warriors I’d rescued from the Poisonblood Grounds last night were their people. Their families.

Not everyone who supported me was doing it because of last night’s rescue, though.

“The Bouyei people also support him. He is more than qualified.”

At the words of the middle-aged female chieftain, one of the chieftains who still had not risen from his seat frowned.

“Wait. What reason do the Bouyei people have? None of your warriors were stationed at Ailao Mountain, were they?”

“Nanman is my homeland.”

“What does that have to—”

“Even beasts that cannot speak repay a kindness. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung risked his life fighting for my homeland last night. Isn’t that reason enough to let him attend?”

“…Ahem.”

The chieftain who had questioned her fell silent after an uncomfortable cough. Warm smiles appeared on other faces.

And amid this atmosphere, so clearly different from the one only a few days ago, I felt a tickle in one corner of my chest.

Repaying someone who helped you. It should be the most natural thing in the world.

But sometimes, in this world, it wasn’t.

I hadn’t gone into the Poisonblood Grounds looking for repayment. Yet here the chieftains were, giving me their gratitude and trust.

Some because I’d helped them last night. Others because of something that had happened long ago.

“My late father, who was once a Great Chieftain, often said things like this after returning from the Great Faction War. ‘If it hadn’t been for the Fire King, I would have gone to the Nine Springs[2851] instead of returning to Nanman.‘ I had completely forgotten those words after his death, but they have finally come back to me.”

“My ancestor destroyed the Five Poisons Sect alongside the Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan at the time. If it hadn’t been for him, our tribe would not have survived to this day. I support him as well.”

Still water began to flow.

Chieftains who had sat in silence rose with the current, one after another, and spoke. Soon more of them were standing than seated.

Then the last person—the one who would put an end to this—finally appeared.

Rumble, rumble—boom!

A giant eight cheok[2852] tall lifted the stone gate, heavy as a thousand geun[2853], with one hand.

The Beast Miao King cast a long, enormous shadow across the hall. He spoke in a low voice.

[2851] The Nine Springs is a traditional Chinese euphemism for the realm of the dead.

[2852] Eight cheok is about 2.42 m (7.95 ft); one cheok is 30.3 cm (11.9 in).

[2853] A thousand Korean geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb); one geun is 600 g (1.32 lb).

“Looks like a conclusion has been reached.”

At the end of his gaze, Baeksang slowly rose and offered him a cool, formal salute.

“I greet you, Palace Lord.”

“Unless my eyes and ears deceive me, he seems more than qualified. Don’t you agree, little brother?”

“It is the wrong choice. You are breaking the rules of a Tribal Grand Council with a long and venerable tradition.”

“More than half the chieftains have agreed to his attendance. Scholars in the Central Plains call that a consensus.”

Baeksang closed his eyes instead of answering. The Beast Miao King did not wait.

“I, Yayul Cheok, Great Chieftain of the Miao people and Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, permit Jin Taekyung—Fire Dragon Pavilion Master of the Murim Alliance and successor to the Fire Gate Clan—to attend the Tribal Grand Council.”

At that moment, a clear bell sounded in my ears.

Ding.

Somewhere damp and sweltering.

In a darkness that lay somewhere between pitch-black and the abyss, voices no one could hear passed back and forth.

—The grand council has begun in the Inner Palace.

—And him?

—He attended as well. But…

—Go on. Don’t hesitate.

—Th-that is…

A moment’s hesitation.

The man sending the Sound Transmission could never have guessed it would cost him his life.

Swish. Slice.

At the faint sounds, a figure hidden in the darkness collapsed.

When the white fingers that had wiped the blood from their cheek moved, the lifeless corpse flew beyond the darkness and vanished.

—So? What happened?

One life was gone in an instant, but someone else soon took the dead man’s place. A tense Sound Transmission followed.

—Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung attended the grand council.

—Who? Jin Taekyung?

—Yes! Apparently he gained permission with the support of the Beast Miao King and the other chieftains.

After a moment’s silence, someone in the darkness clicked their tongue.

—Those barbarian bastards… And you? You just stood there and watched?

—W-what?

—Then again, how could a worm like you be at fault? It was my mistake for keeping a useless worm under my command.

—…!

The person reporting to the entity in the darkness immediately realized the danger, but he could not escape death either.

Swish. Thrust!

Death swept past again. The figure stared down at the corpse swallowed by darkness and murmured,

“Jin Taekyung. It’s been a while.”

Chapter 644

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

A new Quest, Tribal Grand Council, has been created!

Quest

Tribal Grand Council

You have become the first outsider in the history of the Nanman Beast Palace to earn the right to attend the Tribal Grand Council.

This is an achievement that even the Fire Gate Clan's fifth Sect Leader failed to accomplish.

Why? Because he destroyed the Five Poisons Sect and left before the council could even begin!

At this momentous meeting, where the major and minor affairs of Nanman will be decided, you must achieve the best possible result you can right now!

Grade: Supreme Peak

Restriction: Jin Taekyung

Mission: Nanman Beast Palace's entry into the alliance *(Incomplete)*

Reward: ???

Failure: ???

I stared at the Quest window and sighed inwardly.

Public opinion might have turned in my favor, but getting the Nanman Beast Palace to join the alliance? That was every bit as tough as the Quest's Supreme Peak Grade suggested.

And what was that bit about the fifth Sect Leader…?

That was the Fire Gate Clan for you.

A venerable sect of thugs, passed down from one person to the next for hundreds of years. I'd heard that some of its Sect Leaders had lived long lives in seclusion, while others had gone out into Murim, burned like flames, and died young. But every last one of them had been a monster whose might placed him among the top five in the world.

That's probably one reason I'm allowed to sit here.

It might have been over two hundred years ago, but the Nanman Beast Palace and the Fire Gate Clan had a fairly close connection.

By K-Murim logic, it was basically a sect founded by Grandfather Dangun's best friend.[2854]

The problem was, I had a talent for beating people up and none whatsoever for persuading them.

Still, I have to do my best.

I straightened my back and looked around at the thirty-two chieftains seated at the table.

The Beast Miao King occupied the seat of honor. To his left and right sat the great chieftains Baeksang, Yohi, and Heugung, in that order. The others seemed to have been seated without regard to the strength of their tribes.

There weren't many of them, but each chieftain commanded anywhere from several hundred to tens of thousands of tribespeople. In that sense, this gathering was Nanman itself.

As I studied their faces, the Beast Miao King broke the brief silence.

"Well, then."

His expression was solemn, his gaze dignified. The moment he opened his mouth, the air in the hall drew taut as a bowstring.

Radiating all the authority of the master of the Nanman Beast Palace, the Beast Miao King delivered the historic words that would open the council.

"Did everyone eat before coming here?"

"…?"

"We've had some unpleasant things happen lately, but you still shouldn't skip meals. Chief Jang, you in particular look a little thinner than you did last year."

"…!"

Historic, my ass.

What did I just hear?

I was still doubting my ears when Chief Jang—the first to offer me a cupped-fist salute earlier—answered.

"As expected, nothing gets past the Palace Lord's keen eyes. I have lost a little weight."

No. He's actually going along with this?

"I thought so. But a chieftain can't neglect his health. You have to take care of yourself for your tribespeople's sake. How old are you again?"

"Sixty."

"You're still in the prime of life. Eat more."

"Jonmyeong."[2855]

[2854] Dangun is the legendary founder of Korea's first kingdom; "Grandfather Dangun" jokingly invokes a distant shared ancestor.

[2855] *Jonmyeong* means "As you command." It differs by one vowel from *jonmang*, crude slang for being utterly ruined.

Now I was hearing things, too. *Jonmyeong* sounded like *jonmang*—"fucked."

Nanman is fucked.

Was this really the Tribal Grand Council I'd imagined?

I stared at the thirty-two chieftains in disbelief.

These people represented all of Nanman. Yet the Beast Miao King's opening words had apparently been their cue to start conversations all over the hall that made my spirit shrink just listening to them.

"Chief Gal, I heard the news. Your sixth child had their coming-of-age ceremony?"

"My seventh."

"I got them mixed up. If only you'd stopped at one or two. I don't care how vigorous you are—fifteen children?"

"Seventeen."

"…You definitely had fifteen at last year's council."

"We had two more. Twins."

"Oh."

On one side, a super-sperm man seemed to be working toward founding a Nanman soccer league.

"Chief Gu. Return the livestock you stole a while ago."

"What livestock?"

"The fifty-two dairy cows that vanished from the pasture. You think I don't know your tribespeople took them?"

"I have never done such a thing."

"Of course you'd say that. Return them while I'm asking nicely."

"Oh, come on! I'm telling you, we didn't take them!"

"I said hand over the cows while I'm asking nicely, you cow-udder bastard!"

On another, a furious argument raged over who had stolen all those cows.

"I remember it as if it were yesterday. The day you bastards trespassed on our tribe's land."

"Oh, this again? Every damn year. You're barely forty. Why do you keep bringing up something that happened eighty years ago?"

"Because I inherited the spirits of my ancestors. So give me the land."

"How does that make sense? Our predecessors settled this!"

"Give me the land."

"No, seriously…"

"Give me the land."

Elsewhere, a land ghost insisting he had been reincarnated continued his back-and-forth struggle.

As I watched it all in disbelief, someone's Sound Transmission reached my ear.

—That's a funny expression.

I turned my head slightly and met Yohi's eyes. She was watching me with an amused smile.

—The Tribal Grand Council is always like this. Everyone's scattered across Nanman and only gets together once a year, so I suppose it's natural.

I thought for a moment, then answered honestly.

—Even so, this is a complete shitshow.

—The Tribal Grand Council handles all of Nanman's affairs, major and minor. *Minor* means the small ones come up, too.

—…That matter is way too small, though.

—How else are thirty-two tribes supposed to live together in harmony? They settle things one by one when everyone's gathered. It lets them clear up old grudges.

Crash!

"You son of a bitch!"

"Is this bastard out of his mind…?"

"You think your martial arts are that strong? Shut up and come outside."

The two chieftains arguing over the cows had finally grabbed each other by the collars. Yohi looked at them and added:

—Of course, there are exceptions.

—…

—It'll be settled soon. The real grand council starts after that.

"Ah, give me the land. I said give it to me."

"Oh, you Thousand-Year Spider bastard."

"Come to think of it, a thousand years ago, our ancestors…"

"Stop! Stoooop!"

It'll be settled soon, she said.

Hmm. I had my doubts.

Are these people really just a bunch of barbarians…?

I kept that thought to myself. But just as Yohi had said, the chaos began to subside, one dispute at a time, and new matters came up.

"Thirty Man warriors were wounded and twenty-two were killed in this year's ferocious-beast hunt. The beasts seem to have become especially rampant lately, so before the losses grow any larger, we request that the Inner Palace take action…"

"Sudden torrential rain caused a flood. The pasture and around fifty nearby homes were submerged…"

"I report that the dispute between the Huang and Dong tribes has been resolved. Both sides have drawn up an official written agreement and will maintain peace for the next ten years…"

Ferocious-beast hunts. Floods. Tribal disputes.

The appetizers were over. Now the main dishes were coming out.

And among those reports was something that deserved serious attention.

“They say a strange figure has appeared in the northeast.”

A strange figure?

As the question arose in my mind, the Beast Miao King—who until then had merely nodded along with short replies—straightened his posture and spoke.

“A strange figure. This is the first I have heard of it.”

“W-well…”

The chieftain who had raised the matter looked uncertain.

“The information hasn’t been confirmed, so I can’t speak with confidence…”

“Where did it come from?”

“Three days ago, we captured a Han Chinese man who crossed the northeastern border. He told us an unidentified man had appeared out of nowhere and was leaving a trail of blood through Guizhou.”

Guizhou was a border region touching Nanman, along with Sichuan and Guangxi. With a little exaggeration, it was practically close enough to trip and bump your nose against.

But some strange man suddenly appeared in Guizhou?

Something felt off. More than off—it nagged at me. And I wasn’t the only one who sensed there was more to this than the stranger’s unknown identity.

“Tell me more.”

The chieftain swallowed at the sight of the Beast Miao King’s frown.

“Neither his name nor his age is known. They say he’s bald like a monk from the Central Plains and carries a Zen staff. He’s beaten several hundred people to death in Guizhou alone. That’s apparently why they call him the Blood Monk.”

“The Blood Monk?”

“Yes. The Han Chinese man we captured seemed to be a fairly skilled martial artist himself, but he couldn’t hide his fear when he spoke of him.”

The sobriquet was grim enough. Its owner had to possess astonishing martial arts.

Guizhou is orthodox faction territory. The Murim Alliance wouldn’t have just stood by.

Yet the Blood Monk had killed several hundred people and made a name for himself. Without at least Supreme Peak-level martial prowess, that would have been impossible.

It also bothered me that he’d appeared in Guizhou, right beside Nanman.

Could it be…?

An unidentified man appearing at such a strange time. Strong enough to rampage alone through Guizhou, a stronghold of the orthodox faction.

I couldn't help thinking of Dark Heaven. He might not be a major figure on the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's level, but the possibility was there. The Blood Lord and the Western Heaven Demon Lord had commanded Supreme Peak masters like the Yin-Yang Twin Ghosts and the Qilian Three Fiends.

And what if the Blood Monk is headed for Nanman?

For the first time, I spoke to the chieftain.

"Do you know where the Blood Monk is going?"

"I wanted to ask him myself, but there's no way to know now."

"What do you mean?"

The chieftain shook his head with a faint sigh.

"The man died."

"What?"

"He died before I could ask anything else. He was badly injured to begin with, and I don't think he adapted to the sudden change in environment. Then the heavy rain brought a flood, and we couldn't take proper measures."

"…!"

The Blood Monk's appearance. And the death of our only witness.

Silence settled over the hall. Then someone who had said nothing since the council began spoke up.

"Injury, endemic disease, and death. They happen often enough."

Everyone turned toward the voice.

Baeksang.

"The Slaughter Saint appearing in the Central Plains is no different. Han Chinese have always been that way. Though they are one people, they've kept their world going by killing one another. In short…"

His tone and expression remained perfectly calm. His voice was cold.

"There's no reason for Nanman to concern itself with affairs in the Central Plains. None at all."

I did not know whether the thought that came to me then was merely a misunderstanding. But one thing was certain: something about his words felt strange and out of place to me.

Baeksang was the great chieftain of the Bai people, who possessed Nanman's second-largest faction and the second-largest population. And yet he was trying to ignore an event unfolding right beside him.

I watched him for a moment, then spoke.

"What if the Blood Monk is heading south?"

The chieftains who grasped my meaning widened their eyes. Baeksang answered without a trace of hesitation.

“Nanman isn’t the only place bordering Guizhou. Beyond Guangxi lies the open sea. With a favorable wind, one can sail to Hainan in ten days.”

“So you think it’s unlikely the Blood Monk will enter Nanman?”

“Why would he come all the way here? Rather than face venomous beasts, ferocious beasts, and countless Nanman warriors, he could go through Guangxi to the sea…”

“There is a reason. One clear reason. But…”

I forcefully cut him off before he could continue, fixing Baeksang with a grave, steady gaze as I went on.

“Strangely enough, you seem to be the only one who doesn’t know it.”

“What?”

“Or did you agree with someone to pretend you didn’t know from the start?”

At that moment—

Fwoosh. Whoomph.

The wavering torchlight went out.

In the darkness that fell over the vast hall, a pair of eyes radiated a piercing chill.

“You have finally crossed the line.”

Whoosh!

“Well.”

An immense wave of qi bore down on me from every direction, squeezing my entire body. I spoke calmly.

“I think you’re the one crossing it.”

Chapter 645

Who had crossed the line first?

Me? Or Baeksang?

And of the words we'd exchanged, which were true and which were lies?

Questions flashed through my mind, but they no longer mattered. From here on, we would settle the matter as martial artists did: with force.

Whoosh!

A sharp sound cut through the air. Before it reached my ears, I tilted my head aside, dodging the Finger Qi flying toward me. Without hesitation, I planted a hand on the stone table in front of me.

Boom!

The table, carved from a massive boulder, shuddered. Thirty-three wine cups sprang into the air. I reached out and sent several of them toward one person alone.

Tung.

Baeksang.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

They were crude cups, roughly carved from wood. Filled with the internal energy I'd sent into them, they became deadly weapons—faster than arrows, with enough force to shatter stone.

But Baeksang was calm. More importantly, he was strong.

Whoomph! Slash!

He swept his straightened hand blade sideways. Invisible qi cut across the air and split the cups apart.

Before the fragments could hit the floor, Baeksang surged from his seat. His figure blurred.

Papapat!

White robes fluttered like a ghost through the darkness over the hall. In an instant, he had crossed the stone table and closed the five zhang[2856] between us. His fist came down toward the crown of my head.

"You're crossing the line again."

I muttered the words and drove my palm upward.

Fwoosh!

Flame Divine Palm.

Flames consumed the darkness and met Baeksang's fist, which blazed with Force. White and blue energies mingled, bursting into a flash that shook the hall.

[2856] A zhang is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft); five zhang is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

Boom! Rumble-rumble!

A descending fist and an upward palm. An old man and a young man. A collision of raw strength.

The impact rocked the hall.

Whoooosh!

Beyond the light exploding from the point where our attacks met, I saw Baeksang's eyes widen.

"…!"

Baeksang's eyes, which had always shone with a cool light, held unmistakable surprise.

How?

I knew the look. Most of the people I'd faced had worn it.

Before my name and sobriquet had begun spreading through the Murim, and even afterward, people sometimes seemed to forget that and underestimate me too soon—because I was young, came from an insignificant family, or was an inexperienced brat who had never experienced war.

Whenever that happened, I kindly set them straight.

Not with words, but with force.

Just like now.

Along with the mutter that never escaped my lips, I drew up the energy filling my entire body even more forcefully.

Whoooosh!

The tremendous internal energy of no less than three jiazi[2857] stirred to life and stretched. The terrible heat of my Scorching Yang Qi evaporated the moisture around us, and red heat haze rose into the air.

Tsss-tsss-tsss!

Baeksang's fist began to give way against my open palm. His trembling eyes flicked from his burning white robes to my calm face.

A cool voice emerged from between his heat-cracked lips.

"You bastard…"

Remarkable composure. Usually, people in his position went straight to *fucking bastard*, *son of a bitch*, or *crazy bastard*.

But whether he had been tempered by a hundred battles or because he was the Great Chieftain leading tens of thousands of tribespeople, Baeksang's emotions might have surged, but they never overflowed, and his martial prowess was far greater than I had expected.

Swish!

[2857] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle; three jiazi equals 180 years.

A blackened collar brushed against my forearm. At some point, the fist he had clenched tightly had spread open like an eagle's talons and shot toward my wrist with lightning speed.

It would have caught me, too, if I hadn't moved faster and hit harder.

Crack!

I caught his wrist instead and squeezed with strength far beyond human limits. Pain made his brow twitch, and a short groan escaped him.

"Hng!"

I seized the opening.

Now.

I twisted his wrist aside, blocking his other hand and throwing him off balance. Then I drove my free palm into his flank.

Bang!

I released his wrist before the heavy report of the strike reached my ears.

In front of dozens of watching chieftains, Baeksang flew backward. He twisted in midair and landed on the stone table.

Swish.

He touched down so lightly he made no sound. His expression was anything but light.

He fixed me with a heavy stare and started to move again.

"Enough."

The voice was not loud, but it held a deep resonance and authority. The Beast Miao King had risen from his seat and opened his mouth with a hard expression.

"Stand down. Both of you."

Baeksang's figure wavered. I shrugged.

"I didn't move."

That was an undeniable fact. I had pulled my chair back a little, but Baeksang had been the one to charge first. I had exchanged moves with him while remaining seated.

And the result? Well, the other chieftains were staring at me as if they'd seen a ghost. Their faces said it all.

"Jin Taekyung."

I did need to show some propriety. This was Nanman, not my home ground, and Baeksang was the Great Chieftain of the Bai people.

At the Beast Miao King's reproachful call, I raised both hands.

"I'm sorry. It was a situation where I couldn't help using my hands. I just acted without thinking."

I still needed to make that clear. Even if I conceded that I'd started the trouble, Baeksang had used an attack that could have killed me.

"…Hoo."

Perhaps he understood. The Beast Miao King sighed softly and turned to the other man.

"Baeksang, do not act rashly."

Conflict flickered through Baeksang's cold eyes. He kept staring at me without answering the Beast Miao King behind him, then looked around the hall.

More than thirty chieftains watched us. Some shifted in their seats as if ready to rush me. Others fought back smiles. Still others looked half dazed by what they'd just seen.

There were factions within the Nanman Beast Palace. And in front of all of them, Baeksang's standing and Fame had taken a blow that would not be easily erased.

At the hands of a Han Chinese brat from the Central Plains, no less.

"…"

Baeksang knew it. He pressed his lips together and bowed his head to the Beast Miao King.

"I apologize for causing a disturbance. I will see you again after I have calmed my mind."

Then he left the hall, his scorched robes fluttering behind him.

Yohi rose and followed as if it were the most natural thing in the world. Heugung hurried after them, and nearly half the chieftains got up as well, watching one another for cues.

"Palace Lord, forgive me, but I…"

"L-let's go together."

They were probably the pro-Baeksang faction. Unlike the ordinary moderates, they were fiercely opposed to Nanman joining the Murim Alliance.

As roughly half of the thirty-two chieftains filed out, Yayul Mok frowned in anger. The Beast Miao King spoke wearily.

"So it's finally come to this."

I glanced at him before speaking.

"I'm sorry. Feels like this happened because of me."

"Hoo. You have nothing to apologize for. It was bound to happen sooner or later."

"Oh, good. That's what I thought, too."

"…"

The remaining chieftains, Yayul Mok, and the Beast Miao King all gave me the same flat look.

—It *is* because of you, you bastard.

What was that? I must be hearing things. It definitely wasn't Sound Transmission.

I tilted my head at the strange phenomenon, then asked, "The Tribal Grand Council isn't over, is it?"

“The Tribal Grand Council runs for three days, alongside the festival. You were told that before you attended.”

“I was. Just checking.”

The Beast Miao King shook his head at my shameless answer.

“Did you really have to take it that far?”

“It felt too suspicious to let it go. I wanted to see his real reaction, too.”

“That curiosity has made enemies of more than ten thousand Bai people. Add Yohi and Heugung, the two Great Chieftains who follow Baeksang, and the others, and it would be no exaggeration to say that half of Nanman is against you.”

Hmm. Half of Nanman.

“That’s not as bad as I expected.”

“What?”

“Two days ago, all of Nanman was against me. I was about to get thrown out before the Tribal Grand Council even started.”

“…Hah.”

The Beast Miao King gave a hollow laugh and turned to the chieftains who remained.

“Chief Jang. Chief Go.”

“Yes.”

“This time, I will need your help. First, organize a scouting party of fast-moving warriors and have them watch the area toward Guizhou.”

“Because of the Blood Monk?”

The Beast Miao King nodded.

“Both Baeksang and Jin Taekyung have a point. The man has no particular reason to come to Nanman. But if he belongs to Dark Heaven, we should be prepared.”

“We will obey your command, Palace Lord.”

“As you command.”

If the chieftains who had left were Baeksang’s people, most of those still here were loyal to the Beast Miao King or were moderates favorably disposed toward him.

The two chiefs, each the leader of a mid-sized tribe, accepted their orders without protest. The Beast Miao King’s expression eased a little.

“Tonight, we will erect a memorial for those who died and hold a banquet in their honor. The Tribal Grand Council will resume afterward. You may withdraw for now.”

“What happened?”

Namho came rushing over the moment we returned to our quarters.

"You didn't cause another incident, did you?"

His voice brimmed with suspicion. I was about to answer when Hyuk Mujin burst out indignantly.

"Old man Nam! What do you take our Captain for?"

"What else? A lunatic."

"Now, now. Even if our Captain *is* a lunatic, that's going too far! Do you seriously think he'd cause trouble at a meeting that important?"

"Yes. Easily."

Is it normal to feel guilty right now?

I hesitated, then opened my mouth. Or tried to.

That was when Ju Hwaran joined in.

"Elder Namho, that's too harsh. How can you call our Pavilion Master a lunatic?"

If Taishan was the reason Namho was aging so quickly, Ju Hwaran was his one weakness. The man who had been so sure of himself a moment ago scratched his thinning crown.

"Well, I…"

"Our Pavilion Master came here representing the Murim Alliance. He can be a little rough around the edges, but he knows how important it is to secure Nanman's entry into the alliance. He would never cause a disturbance at the Tribal Grand Council."

"…"

Please kill me.

My conscience had gone past pricking me. It hurt.

Meanwhile, Ju Hwaran was canvassing the others like an enthusiastic campaigner.

"What do you all think? Why isn't anyone answering?"

The usually quiet Song Ilseom smacked his lips.

"Hmm. Young Bureau Head, perhaps we ought to hear from the man himself first…"

"Extra bonus."

"On second thought, you're right. The Pavilion Master would never do such a thing."

Money-crazed bastard—out.

"Why aren't the other two saying anything?"

"Taishan. Hungry…"

"I heard there's a banquet tonight."

"Taishan. Strongly agrees with Young Lady Ju."

"…I agree as well."

Glutton—out. Ex-fiancé I could chew to bits and still not feel satisfied—out.

Her petition gathered signatures with the speed of Quick Attack.[2858] Then Ju Hwaran turned eyes sparkling like the Milky Way on me.

“Pavilion Master, say something. So, have you decided to join the alliance?”

One second felt like an hour.

After a long silence, I spoke.

“Um. Everyone. Well. There was… a minor problem.”

Ju Hwaran froze. Namho nodded as if he’d known all along.

“See? Crazy Pavilion Master.”

“…”

“Did you kill someone?”

“No.”

“Then you hit someone.”

“…”

“Who? Some chieftain who picked a fight without knowing better? Or someone who said something you didn’t like? Surely not the Great Chieftain of the Bai people.”

“Ah.”

“Pavilion Master?”

“…”

“…Pavilion Master?”

As Ju Hwaran’s voice grew faint, I kept my mouth shut and stared toward a distant mountain.

Namho chuckled.

“See? Crazy bastard.”

[2858] Quick Attack is a move in the Pokémon games.

Chapter 646

If this continued, I was liable to be branded a traitor guilty of high treason, so in the end, I had to explain everything that had happened at the Tribal Grand Council from beginning to end.

And answer every question that came up along the way.

“More than half the chieftains accepted you?”

“Yes. They even gave me cupped-fist salutes.[2859] Thanked me for saving their tribespeople and families.”

“My goodness. You were gone so long that I had a feeling something had happened… But an outsider—especially a Han Chinese person—attending the Tribal Grand Council must be a first in Nanman’s history. No, in Murim history.”

At Ju Hwaran’s surprise, Namho, who stood beside her, added with a warm smile.

“Of course it’s a first. An outsider attending the Tribal Grand Council was a first, and that outsider getting into a fight with the Great Chieftain of the Bai people was a first too. Yes, indeed.”

“…”

“…”

“Hoho. I’m laughing because I’m so very proud and happy. Don’t mind me. Go on.”

It was hard *not* to mind him, but I went on.

“Anyway, the council started, and…”

Ju Hwaran’s eyes widened as she listened.

“The Blood Monk?”

“Yes. Apparently, he’s rampaging through Guizhou right now. I heard he’s already beaten several hundred people to death and is running wild. This was the first time I’d heard that sobriquet, so I was wondering if Young Lady Ju had ever heard of him.”

The Yongbong Escort Bureau was based in Sichuan, which bordered Guizhou to the southeast. And though the bureau’s fortunes had declined for a time, it had once been among the foremost Escort Bureaus in the world. Its intelligence network was considerable.

Young Lady Ju might know something.

But my hopes faded when I told her what little I knew about the Blood Monk and she shook her head.

“I’m sorry. A few sobriquets vaguely come to mind, but none of them belonged to a master of that caliber. Besides, there’s no specific sketch or description of his appearance.”

[2859] A cupped-fist salute places one fist against the opposite open palm as a greeting or sign of respect in Chinese martial culture.

"Hmm. I see."

I was a little disappointed, but I tried not to show it. As she'd said, picking one man out from a handful of characteristics, without even a proper description of his face, was difficult.

All I'd been able to tell her was that he was probably middle-aged, his martial arts were likely at the Supreme Peak level, and his signature weapon was a Zen staff.

Murim's a big place.

Not just in terms of land. There were plenty of people, too. Men with cheap swords made of scrap iron gave themselves names like Soaring Dragon Guest and Sword Demon, then strutted around as if they were somebody.

I might as well search an endless beach for one grain of sand.

I was smacking my lips when Ju Hwaran, who still looked apologetic, seemed to remember something.

"Oh, but Captain Song would know more about this than I would. Wouldn't you, Captain Song?"

Oh. Right.

Every eye in the room, including mine, turned toward Song Ilseom. As usual, he'd been keeping quiet.

"Hmm. I don't know."

Like hell you don't.

I'd figured him out by now. I tossed him a silver nyang.[2860]

"Hey, Soul-Chasing Guest. If you know something, let's hear it."

He might call himself a mere escort these days, but Song Ilseom was a martial arts prodigy of Guangdong Chen Family blood. At a startlingly young age, he'd won more than a hundred life-and-death duels and become a legend among wandering martial artists.

In some ways, there were few professions more sensitive to people and rumors than wandering martial artists. Their lives could depend on it from one day to the next.

Clack.

Song Ilseom snatched the silver out of the air and frowned.

"You think I'm obsessed with money?"

"Yes."

"…"

"So, you don't like it?"

"I don't dislike it."

"What if I give you more?"

[2860] A nyang was a traditional unit of currency. "Silver nyang" refers to silver money, not modern Korean won.

“I’d like that even better.”

“Here. Have some more silver, you money-crazed bastard.”

Whoosh. Clack.

“…Somehow, this feels even worse.”

Having secured a generous bonus, Song Ilseom began, looking vaguely uncomfortable. “Middle-aged, and he uses a Zen staff?”

“Yeah. Steel, from what I heard.”

“What does he look like?”

“I don’t know much beyond the bald head and lack of a beard. The survivor who made it all the way to Nanman died after telling them that much.”

“A complete mess, then. Still, three people come to mind. Not many martial artists use a Zen staff as their signature weapon.”

“Oh, three?”

“There’s just one problem…”

“That’s fine. Tell me.”

With all of us watching him expectantly, Song Ilseom spoke.

“He’s dead.”

“Huh?”

“More precisely, I killed him. Took a commission and happened to meet him on a battlefield.”

“Hmm… Well, that happens. What about the other two?”

“What do you mean, the other two?”

“You just said you killed one.”

“I killed all three.”

“…?”

“Two on battlefields, one in a life-and-death duel. The last was the strongest.”

“…!”

A heavy silence fell. Then Namho muttered what everyone was thinking.

“So there’s another crazy bastard.”

I didn’t know who the *other* crazy bastard was supposed to be, but I couldn’t agree more.

I glared at Song Ilseom, who stood there blankly. Should I take back the silver first and then beat him up? Or beat him up first and then take back the silver?

That was when I noticed someone else giving him a look of utter contempt.

“Hey, unorthodox grunt.”

“…Unorthodox grunt?”

“Yeah. Know anything?”

Sama Pyo, Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate—the most powerful unorthodox faction in the world today, and self-proclaimed ruler of Gansu—knitted his brows.

"I have three things to say. First, I am not an unorthodox grunt. Second, Gansu and Guizhou are nearly a thousand li[2861] apart, so travel between them is difficult. And third, why would you think I'd know?"

"Because you're part of the unorthodox faction."

"…?"

"Bad guys all know each other, don't they?"

"…!"

"Well, maybe not."

I waved a hand at Sama Pyo, who had gone stiff as a statue, and turned to the other, enormous unorthodox grunt beside him.

Before I could say a word, I got a booming answer.

Grrrrowl. Grrrrrrrrowl.

"…"

What the fuck?

This wasn't the World Cup final, yet a vuvuzela was blaring in the middle of Nanman. Namho burst out laughing.

"Hoho! That bastard. If only I'd learned martial arts, I'd cut that goddamn belly open. Hahaha!"

Given how much he'd been laughing, he seemed about halfway out of his mind. Hyuk Mujin stared at him in fear, then turned to me.

"Captain."

"Head to the floor."

"What?"

"Ah, sorry. That was just a habit. But if you start talking nonsense like the others in this situation, I'll kill you."

"No, that's not it. This Blood Monk or whatever he's called… Isn't there too little information about him for a martial artist?"

It was the most sensible thing anyone had said since Ju Hwaran spoke. I scratched the back of my head in frustration and smacked my lips.

"That's true. How fucking old is he, anyway? How is there not a single person who knows him?"

Namho, who'd been shooting Taishan a murderous glare, cut in.

"Speaking as someone who's old enough to know, I've never heard of him either. There was a fiend called the Killing Buddha during the Great Faction War, but he

[2861] In China, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

doesn't sound much like this Blood Monk. The man was ancient even then. I doubt he's still alive."

If Namho had been just some old man from another tribe, that might not have meant much. But he'd held a fairly important post in the Hidden Shadow Pavilion. Chances were he was right.

Then who the hell is this guy? He sounds like some hidden master.

If even Namho, a man from the distant past, and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members of the current generation had never heard of him, then he was truly a freak.

But what mattered most wasn't the Blood Monk's identity. It was who stood behind him—and what he wanted.

Namho tapped his knees, as if he'd read my mind.

"We can't be sure yet, but there's a strong chance Dark Heaven is behind the Blood Monk."

"I agree. I said as much at the Tribal Grand Council."

"What do the Beast Miao King and the other chieftains think?"

"We decided to send some scouts and warriors toward Guizhou first, but before that… Baeksang's reaction bothered me."

"He told you not to concern yourselves with affairs in the Central Plains, I suppose."

"Huh?"

"He's done it often enough. Ever since the Great Faction War, Baeksang has bristled at anything to do with the Central Plains. Even the few trade routes Nanman had were closed after the Bai people and several other tribes opposed them. What I wonder now is…"

Namho sighed quietly before continuing.

"Does his hostility come from the grief of losing his only child in a war between Han Chinese? Or did something that happened then leave him with a grudge against the orthodox faction?"

"Hmm."

"If it's the former, it may end with a bereaved father's resentment. But if it's the latter…"

Ju Hwaran, who had been listening in silence, murmured, "Betrayal. Enough to put all of Nanman in danger."

"Yes. If he's joined hands with Dark Heaven, this could spiral beyond anyone's control."

An enemy within was more dangerous than one outside. Even an impregnable fortress was no better than a sandcastle in the surf if it crumbled from the inside.

And if the traitor was the Great Chieftain who, alongside the Beast Miao King, held sway over half of Nanman—

We're finished.

I had to uncover the plot taking shape inside Nanman and stop it. I also had to find out where the Blood Monk was headed as he made his way onward from distant Guizhou.

But even the System that had brought me from an F-rank Hunter to where I stood now couldn't split me in two.

In that case…

I raised my head and slowly looked over everyone around me.

I recalled their martial arts, characteristics, and personalities one by one as I considered who was best suited for the task. Who could return alive from an unknown danger?

I was deep in thought, with no end to it in sight, when someone spoke.

"I'll go."

"…!"

"Please send me. I will complete the mission and return without fail."

I was startled twice: first that she'd understood what I was thinking without a word from me, and then that the person who'd spoken was Ju Hwaran.

My answer came out as if I'd settled on it from the start.

"No."

"Why? Do you think that old monster, the Blood Monk, will hurt me?"

"That's…"

"My martial arts may be meager compared to yours, Pavilion Master, but I believe I am strong enough to protect myself."

"Young Lady Ju."

"I know what you're worried about. Of course I couldn't take on the Blood Monk. But warriors handpicked by the Nanman Beast Palace will be with us, and some of our members will come, too. Tell me if I'm wrong."

I pressed my lips together instead of answering. She wasn't wrong.

I'd planned to send some Fire Dragon Pavilion members with the scouting party that would soon depart. They would find out who the Blood Monk was and what he wanted, and I'd accounted for the possibility of a fight.

What I hadn't considered was Ju Hwaran volunteering.

"Pavilion Master. No—Benefactor."

Benefactor.

That was what she'd first called me months ago, just after we'd settled the Yongbong Escort Bureau's affairs in Sichuan.

For a moment, I could almost smell the flowers in the Fire Courtyard, where we'd taken our last walk before leaving. The eyes that had been wet beneath the moonlight then now shone with firm resolve.

"Please send me. Send me."

"…!"

"I can do it."

A thought came to me.

I would never be able to refuse a request made with those eyes and that voice. Not now, not ever.

Whew.

The wind was hot. My mouth tasted bitter.

I let out a small sigh and finally nodded.

Ju Hwaran's face lit up. In the distance, music announcing the start of the banquet was already playing.

Chapter 647

The banquet was being held in a large training ground inside the Inner Palace.

The place was large enough to accommodate more than a thousand warriors. Every kind of delicacy had been laid out, and the grounds were packed with people, including the tribal chieftains.

And at the most honored seat in the training ground, someone was waiting for me.

“You’ve arrived.”

The Beast Miao King spotted me from his high-backed chair adorned with tiger skin and beckoned me over.

“Come sit. I had a place prepared for you.”

The seat assigned to me was directly beside the Beast Miao King, on his left.

It was exceptional treatment for an outsider, but given my status and what I’d done the previous night, it wasn’t all that strange.

That didn’t mean every member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion was getting the same treatment, of course.

“I’ve prepared places for all of you at this banquet as well. Eat, drink, and enjoy your—”

“Taishan! Meat!”

Grab! Chomp, chomp, chomp!

Taishan swept up the meat on the table in front of him. The Beast Miao King stared at me, baffled.

“…What in the world is that fellow?”

“…He’s just insane. Don’t pay him too much attention.”

At a glance from me, Taishan’s mom—no, Sama Pyo—let out a long sigh, grabbed Taishan, and dragged him away. Namho, who’d been watching for an opening like an assassin, snatched up a nearby wine bottle and smashed it against the top of Taishan’s head.

Crash!

Water Style without any water…?

He’d really put his back into that one.

But Taishan drank from the fountain of wine bursting over his head and cried out happily.

“Namho! Thank you! Taishan was thirsty!”

“Die. Please, just die…!”

The Beast Miao King watched them, then turned an uneasy look on me.

“Hmm. Your subordinates get along well.”

“They do. So well that one could die and the other wouldn’t notice.”

"Is that why you didn't send them?"

I paused before answering. "You heard about that? News travels fast."

"I don't involve myself in every matter, but I hear about them all. That is the position of Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace."

He had a point. Since outsiders had joined the scouts, it wouldn't have been strange for a report to have already reached him through the great chieftains.

I thought of the three people who should be heading somewhere northeast by now and muttered inwardly.

Will they be all right?

After a great deal of thought, I'd chosen three people: Ju Hwaran, Song Ilseom, and Hyuk Mujin.

Regardless of my concerns, Ju Hwaran possessed exceptional martial prowess and experience compared to other young prodigies. Song Ilseom needed no explanation, and the last member, Hyuk Mujin, was…

Whatever else you could say about him, the man has the survival instincts of a cockroach.

Despite how he looked, Hyuk Mujin had survived countless battlefields alongside me, from Shanxi Province to the present day, escaping death at every turn.

He was so good at wriggling his way out of danger that Jeok Cheongang had once said,

How has someone so weak and cowardly survived this long?

I'd answered:

Because he's weak and cowardly.

It was true that Hyuk Mujin's martial arts fell short of the others'. Calling him cowardly wasn't wrong, either.

But you could also call it caution.

He has an uncanny knack for avoiding the worst danger. And when he can't avoid it, he fights for his life.

No wonder he always came back alive. I might as well change his nickname to Hyukroach.

"They'll do well. No matter what happens."

I muttered that with a personal wish behind it, then glanced over the Beast Miao King's shoulder.

"By the way, there are a lot of empty seats for a banquet that's already started."

"They'll be here soon."

He said it casually, but the Beast Miao King's eyes had grown heavy and dark. This was especially true whenever he looked at the empty seat directly to his right.

Baeksang.

The chieftains who had left the main hall following him were already seated, but Baeksang, Yohi, and Heugung had yet to return.

The Beast Miao King stared at their empty seats for a while before silently tilting the wine bottle.

Drip.

The sun had long since set behind the western mountains, yet the Nanman Beast Palace glowed against the darkness. Festivities were taking place everywhere.

The Tribal Grand Council, held only once a year, was also an occasion for unity, and the countless tribespeople who had poured into the streets were laughing and talking with bright faces as they enjoyed themselves.

Or, at least, they probably were. I couldn't see them from here, but the cheers and firecracker explosions drifting over from the Outer Palace were more than enough to tell me.

Whoosh! Boom!

Waaaaaaah!

If I only listened to the noise, I would have thought it was at least a Samba Festival.

"So, um… Is this really okay?"

"What do you mean?"

"You know. Everyone seems to have amnesia. They all know what happened at Ailao Mountain barely a day ago."

He didn't seem concerned. "They do. That's why the festival is even grander."

"Because of that?"

"Yes. Every one of them was a brave warrior who fought and died for Nanman. So they believe that each of them has returned to the arms of the god their tribe worships. Though they died in this world, they believe they were reborn as warriors of their god."

"…"

I'd heard something like that before.

It brought to mind the Middle Eastern terrorist group I'd beaten up before logging in.

They aren't Crusaders or ancient Vikings.

All kinds of superstitions ran rampant in the Central Plains as well, but Nanman was clearly different. Perhaps it was because so many indigenous faiths existed here.

As someone born and raised in the twenty-first century, though, I couldn't understand it.

"Do you believe that too, Great Hero Yayul?"

At my question, the Beast Miao King, who had been about to raise his wine cup, let out a short laugh.

“Interesting.”

“What is?”

“Isn’t it only natural? You asked that question of an old Miao man born and raised in Nanman—and of the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, at that.”

“Oh.”

“But that isn’t why I laughed. It reminded me that someone else asked me the same thing a very long time ago.”

I had a pretty good idea who. “My Old Master—no, my master?”

“Old Jeok? No. He had no interest in whether the local gods existed. He did tell me to call him if those Demonic Cult bastards ever set Nanman on fire. He said he’d gladly come help, at least once.”

“…”

That old man hated leaving home, yet he’d volunteered to travel here for some killing. His grudge over Mount Jiuhua must have gone right down to the bone.

I nodded reflexively. “Then who asked you?”

His answer was simple, clear, and baffling.

“God.”

“Sorry? What?”

As I stood there, momentarily dumbfounded by the incomprehensible answer, the Beast Miao King continued while stroking his full wine cup.

“The Martial God. Someone whose name, age, and even face are not properly known. A divine man who was born human and became something beyond humanity. That person asked me whether I truly believed my god existed.”

“…!”

“So I answered, ‘Honestly, I don’t know. But I think I’m looking at one right now.‘”

The crescent moon reflected in his wine cup rippled. The Beast Miao King downed the wine and moon together, then burst into laughter.

“It was a foolish answer, but what else could I say? That day, the Martial God single-handedly defeated five fiends who had reached the Supreme Peak realm and five hundred members of the Blood Ghost Squad. When I first met him, he had a snow-white beard that fluttered like an immortal’s. At our second and final meeting, he looked like a young boy.”

“…”

“More than fifty years have passed, but I still remember that day as clearly as ever.”

I listened with my mouth hanging open, unable to speak.

The Blood Ghost Squad. I knew the name. It came up whenever Jeok Cheongang launched into one of his “back in my day” stories.

The Blood Ghost Squad had been the Demonic Cult's premier strike force, sweeping across the Central Plains at the head of a hundred thousand demonic troops. Every single member was said to have been a Peak master.

Five hundred Peak masters. And five fiends at the Supreme Peak realm on top of that.

The Martial God had wiped out that entire force alone.

Even coming from the Beast Miao King, I would have dismissed the story as nonsense if not for those two words: *Martial God.*

…Just how powerful was he?

Jeok Cheongang. Mungyeong. Mae Jonghak. And others.

I had heard stories about the Martial God until my ears bled from people who deserved to be called giants in the long history of the Murim.

And yet I still didn't know. What kind of realm had that master reached? No—was he even human at all?

And why had someone so extraordinary suddenly vanished without a trace? Where was he now, and what was he doing?

One thought led to another. Then, without warning, someone's name came to mind.

…Wait.

The fingers tapping against the table stopped dead.

My eyes flew open, but they were not looking at the banquet hall before me. Nor were they looking at the Murim.

They were looking beyond the hot, heavy air blowing in from far away—beyond some unknown realm that could not be explained in words—to another world and the person who existed there.

Cheon Taemin.

The savior who'd rescued humanity from the Demon King Asmodeus. An immortal legend, called a living god by his followers.

A man who had one day been cut off from the world and fallen into a deep sleep.

I knew exactly why I'd thought of him.

He's like the Martial God.

It could have been a coincidence, but they had too much in common to dismiss it so easily. The Martial God's exploits in the Great Faction War and Cheon Taemin's in the Great Cataclysm—even their actions immediately afterward.

No way. No. No, that's impossible.

I couldn't follow the thought any further. The musicians had stopped playing, the dancers had stopped moving, and every eye was on the man climbing the stairs.

"Welcome, little brother."

Baeksang, flanked by great chieftains as though he were the Palace Lord himself, answered the Beast Miao King's greeting.

“I’m late, Palace Lord.”

I came out of my thoughts and finally met his gaze, cold enough to freeze everything around him.

The banquet has begun.

Security in the Outer Palace has been reinforced.

About two hundred elite warriors from the Inner Palace are moving through the North Gate.

As the Sound Transmissions from her subordinates pierced the darkness one after another, someone buried in the shadows rose from her seat.

Final report. What is the target?

The Blood Monk of Guizhou. The targets are moving for reconnaissance and possible combat. At Jin Taekyung’s order, the group includes Ju Hwaran, the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau; Song Ilseom, the Soul-Chasing Guest; and Hyuk Mujin of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

It would have been surprising for anyone to know Song Ilseom’s past, known to only a select few. Not for the shadow and her subordinates.

“Ha.”

After letting out a quiet laugh, the shadow turned around in one smooth motion.

Snap.

Fingers struck together in the darkness. A strand of flame sprang up, casting light around it.

Fwoosh.

The flame was a dark, ominous reddish brown. Watching it flicker, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled.

Chapter 648

It was as though the world had stopped.

The music cut off all at once, as if on cue. People froze in place.

In the sudden silence, the Beast Miao King spoke, breaking Baeksang's cold stare.

"Little brother, take your seat."

Baeksang's gaze slowly left me. Perhaps he had changed in the meantime; his sleeves were now snow-white as he resumed his climb.

"Very well."

Step. Step.

His clothes were neat and his voice calm, just as they had been in the main hall, as though nothing had happened. He climbed the stairs with two great chieftains flanking him, and bitterness seemed to cloud the Beast Miao King's eyes as he watched.

I suppose that's understandable.

One called him little brother. The other answered, "Palace Lord."

They weren't related by blood, but I'd heard they had grown up together as sworn brothers. Yet I had never once heard Baeksang call the Beast Miao King *hyung*[2862].

A thought occurred to me.

What was the Beast Miao King to Baeksang?

A sworn elder brother he still felt some affection for?

Or merely the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, someone above him in the hierarchy?

Or perhaps…

An enemy whose involvement in the Great Faction War had cost him his only son?

I didn't know. But I had a feeling I would find out soon enough, one way or another.

I hoped it would go well. The Beast Miao King seemed to hope so too.

"It's been a long time since this foolish elder brother filled your cup."

Baeksang looked silently at the wine bottle in the Beast Miao King's hand, then answered in a dry voice.

"I've kept away from wine and women for decades. I must respectfully decline."

The Nanman Beast Palace might be a tribal society governed through a kind of divided rule, but the Palace Lord's authority was considerable. Only Baeksang could have refused him like that. Before he was the Great Chieftain of the Bai people, he was the Beast Miao King's sworn younger brother.

[2862] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“You liked fruit wine when you were young. Won’t you even accept a drink poured by me now? I made this wine myself for you.”

“…”

“Baeksang.”

At the quiet call, tinged with hurt and bitterness, Baeksang slowly closed his eyes, opened them again, and raised his cup.

“If you insist, I suppose I have no choice.”

“Then…”

“I’ll accept the cup, at least.”

The Beast Miao King’s face brightened. He filled Baeksang’s cup to the brim, then whispered softly enough that only Baeksang and I could hear.

“I hope you’ll both forget what happened in the main hall. You each wronged the other. There’s no use blaming either of you alone.”

Baeksang was still suspicious, and I still didn’t like him. But I wasn’t stupid enough to hit the gas now.

“All right. I did go a little too far.”

“…”

Baeksang gave me an unreadable look, then nodded slightly.

“I apologize for my unseemly behavior, Palace Lord.”

It was a surprisingly compliant answer.

The Beast Miao King smiled with satisfaction. Turning to the crowd, he called out, “Today is a joyous occasion for every tribe of Nanman and our honored guests who have traveled all the way from the Central Plains. Eat and drink to your hearts’ content!”

His voice rang across the quiet training ground. The music started again, and the men and women dancing picked up where they had left off.

At last, the mood began to ease.

Then a Sound Transmission reached my ear, hard as stone.

—Honored guests from the Central Plains, are we? How amusing.

Aha. I knew that had gone too smoothly.

I scratched the bridge of my nose and glanced at the Beast Miao King. He had risen and was encouraging the chieftains around him and the warriors they had brought, unaware of what was happening behind him.

—Leave. There is no place for you in this land.

I drained my cup in one gulp and moved my lips.

—Our great chieftain isn’t very generous, is he? I know you hate the Han Chinese, but how many people did I rescue at Ailao Mountain last night?

—I’ll pay you.

—What?

—What do you want? Gold? Silver? Name it. I'll give you gold and silver treasures heavier than your own body.

—…Hmm.

The sweet fragrance of the fruit wine turned bitter, just like my mood.

Gold and silver treasures.

I'd expected a cold reception, but this felt far worse than I'd imagined. I refilled my cup and sent another Sound Transmission.

—I didn't do it for a reward. Do people in Nanman put a price on human lives?

—Of course not. The life of a tribesman is beyond price. But it's different when the other party is Han Chinese.

—Why?

—Because you people…

The Sound Transmission trailed off. Baeksang stared at his full cup with gloomy gray eyes, then shook his head.

—I've said too much. Stop arguing and leave.

—If you stop there, I won't sleep tonight. Why not tell me what's bothering you, and we can look for a way to settle it?

—A way to settle it?

He gave a short laugh.

It was the first time I'd seen Baeksang laugh, and there was no mistaking the contempt and mockery in it.

Clink—crash!

The sound was nearly lost beneath the banquet, but I saw and heard it clearly. His porcelain cup struck the ground and shattered, sending wine splashing in every direction.

Trickle. Drip.

As the spilled fruit wine soaked the stone steps and dripped from one to the next, Baeksang's Sound Transmission reached me again.

—It is already too late to turn things back. Just like those.

—Hmm.

Too late? Is it really?

I studied the broken cup, then reached out.

Fwoosh!

A thread of internal energy flowed from my fingertips and swept gently across the ground. As though time had turned backward, the pieces that had lost their shape moments ago rose and flew into my open hand.

Sss. Tick, tick!

Dozens of fragments drew together like magnets. I used internal energy to bind their broken edges until they formed a cup again.

"…!"

"…!"

A murmur rippled through the onlookers. I subtly turned my head to look around. The reactions of those who had been watching us from earlier were quite a sight.

Namho and Heugung stood frozen with their mouths hanging open. A strange light flashed through Sama Pyo and Yohi's eyes. Taishan had even forgotten to chew his meat and was staring blankly.

Not bad. My control over internal energy really has gotten finer since I opened my Middle Dantian.

If nothing else, stopping Taishan from eating was an achievement worth celebrating.

"Hmm, good. That's some excellent Seizing an Object Through Empty Space."

Baeksang watched me praise myself and spoke in an even voice.

"Was that meant to show off your martial arts? It's a pitiful cup for all your effort."

"Pitiful?"

"It can't hold anything. The wine will leak out before you can pour it in."

He wasn't entirely wrong. I wasn't a god. Short of turning back time, I couldn't restore the cup perfectly. I must have missed some fragments, because hairline cracks ran all through it. Even I couldn't recover the wine that had already soaked into the ground and the steps.

But…

"You're so damn picky. Just drink it."

I picked up the bottle and poured without hesitation—not merely filling the cup, but letting the wine overflow. Then I wrapped my whole hand around it to cover the places where it leaked and tipped it into my mouth.

Gulp.

My throat burned as if I'd swallowed fire. When I spoke, my voice came out heated, carrying the fragrant scent of fruit wine.

"What's the big deal? Cracked or broken, if you can put something in it and drink from it, it's a cup."

"…!"

Baeksang's gaze darkened.

—And what will you do about the wine spilled on the ground long ago?

Anyone else hearing that might have wondered what on earth he was talking about. But it sounded different to me after our earlier exchange of Sound Transmissions.

The cup is trust. The spilled wine is people.

During the Great Faction War, the Nanman Beast Palace had been forced to lose countless tribespeople. Afterward, because of some matter he did not even want to mention, Baeksang had completely lost his trust in the Central Plains.

By putting the shattered cup back together, I'd tried to show him what I meant.

I don't know whether he'll take this as a plea to trust once more or as a final warning…

Either way, I'd made my meaning clear.

I looked across the training ground, where the banquet was in full swing. At the center of the countless cheering people stood the Beast Miao King, watching me with profound eyes.

Whoa. That man doesn't miss a thing.

I felt like a high school kid caught causing trouble. I gave him a deliberate shrug, rose, and ambled off.

"Where are you going?" Baeksang asked behind me.

I threw back a brief answer in a deep voice.

"To take a piss!"

That fruit wine was surprisingly strong.

"Kh… urk!"

He was a bear of a man. But his towering, eight-cheok[2863] frame and more than a jiazi's[2864] worth of internal energy weren't enough to save him from the death before him.

Crunch!

"Urk… Y-you. Who are you?"

A hand held his throat in an unyielding grip. Blood ran from the crown of his head, and between that and the lack of air, his vision had gone red and blurry.

He drew on every last bit of strength he had to speak.

"P-please… s-save me…"

He wanted to live. Desperately. But the strange man gripping his throat had other ideas.

Crack!

Bone broke, and the whites of the man's eyes showed. When the life left him and his body went limp, the stranger released his grip.

Thud!

[2863] A *cheok* is a traditional Korean length of about 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Eight cheok is about 2.42 m (7 ft 11 in).

[2864] A *jiazi* is one complete sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar.

The heavy body rolled onto the ground. Without a moment's hesitation over the life he had taken, the stranger thought, *Ah. Was that the last one?*

Only half a shichen[2865] had passed since enemies suddenly appeared at both ends of the gorge and shouted:

"I'll tear you apart and kill you to avenge my martial brothers and friends!"

"Kill him!"

That was how the one-against-many battle had begun. After killing the men who rushed him from every direction without pause, he'd lost count.

About two hundred, I'd say.

They had gathered quite a force. The outcome had been all but decided from the start, though.

A sea of corpses and blood.

Only those four characters could describe the sight. The stranger, having once again left his mark on an unnamed gorge in Guizhou, picked up the weapon he had left leaning against a rock.

Clang. Clatter.

His Zen staff rattled as it swayed.

Stepping through a pool of blood, he headed somewhere to the south.

[2865] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Chapter 649

Magic and machines.

Compared to the modern world, with all its technological conveniences, the Murim was a difficult place to live.

Its unpaved roads could wreck your hips and back even if all you did was sit in a carriage.

Smartphones and Wi-Fi were out of the question, and there wasn't any electricity. The only way to get some was to take a direct lightning strike, but trading your life for electricity was terrible value for money.

Still, I'd managed to live without any of it.

No—my life had been so precarious that I'd never had time to worry about it. After that, things had been more or less fine.

They say food, clothing, and shelter are the three essentials of life. By that measure, I'd lived pretty luxuriously as the Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Except for one thing.

I fixed a grave stare on the non-Han servant from the Inner Palace. Even being generous, he looked no older than a middle schooler.

"I'm going to ask you one thing. Think carefully before you answer."

"Yes?"

"Are you looking down on me because I'm Han Chinese?"

His eyes went round, and he waved his hands.

"N-no, sir. How could this lowly one dare…"

"Then why did you bring me to this shithole? I'm pretty sure I asked you to take me to the latrine."

"T-this is the latrine, sir."

"I told you to think carefully. Lie to me again, and I'll fill your house with shit. You've heard of the Beggars' Sect in the Central Plains, right?"

"Yes? Yes. Isn't that the sect made up of beggars?"

"Exactly. One word from me, and I can bring several thousand beggars here… Well, maybe not thousands. About a hundred. One of them, Gung Gibang, smells absolutely monstrous. They'll shit-dismember you and all nine generations of your family. So take me to a proper latrine!"

The servant flinched at my roar, his eyes filling with tears.

"I-I'm sorry. I'm truly sorry, but this is the cleanest latrine we have."

Damn it. I'd hoped I was wrong, but this shithole really was the latrine.

The truth I didn't want to face made my vision go dark. Even the Central Plains hadn't been this bad.

“These savages…”

“Sir?”

“Never mind. You can go.”

I sent the innocent servant away, stared into the narrow space full of a hideous stench, and carefully set one foot inside.

Creeeak.

The plank beneath me shrieked. Once I shut the door, I felt like I’d stepped into a chemical-warfare chamber built for one. Grim-faced, I muttered to myself.

Did Baeksang dig this trap for me?

I’d seen it plenty of times in martial-arts novels: some incredible master gets assassinated in a latrine, or something like that.

But after I checked the gaps between the planks, even that suspicion vanished. No matter how dedicated an assassin was, I couldn’t imagine one hiding down there.

Please. God. Buddha. Namu Amitabha, Guanyin, amen…

Every second felt like ten years.

It was just as I had accepted reality and was holding my breath while doing my business.

Whoosh—thud!

It happened in an instant.

I reached out on reflex and caught the object that had punched through the old door with a sharp whistle.

An arrow?

The moment I recognized it, I shot into motion like lightning.

Boom!

The door shattered, and fresh night air greeted me. But that was all.

There was nothing around me. Nothing except the cheers and musical instruments I could hear from somewhere not too far away.

Still…

Southeast.

At my level, working out where the arrow had come from wasn’t difficult. I kicked off the ground without hesitation.

Boom! Whoosh!

Wind swept over me. I sprang off a wall and landed atop the highest pavilion, with the Inner Palace spread out below.

Torches lit the grounds. People enjoyed the banquet at the training ground. Warriors stood guard everywhere.

Who the hell was it?

Even someone in the Supreme Peak realm had limits. The Inner Palace was too vast to search at a glance, and several times more people than usual were moving through it.

Unfortunately for me, the Nanman Beast Palace warriors on alert for trouble took their duties seriously.

“Southwest! On the pavilion!”

“Who goes there?”

Peeeep!

At the sharp blast of a whistle, the warriors patrolling the Inner Palace swarmed toward me like ants.

Something else arrived first.

Whoooosh! Boom!

Hmm. This has gotten a little complicated.

I looked at the arrow and spear embedded near my feet, then checked the arrow in my hand again. It was identical to the new arrivals in size and shape.

But there was one important difference I’d missed.

This is…

A small leather bundle hung from its fletching.

The moment I realized it was there, dozens of torches flared to life beneath the pavilion where I stood.

“You’re surrounded!”

“Identify yourself and surrender immediately!”

Perfect timing.

After a brief moment’s thought, I silently gave a command.

Open Inventory. Store.

Ding.

At the System’s clear chime, the arrow vanished from my hand as if it had never existed.

Unable to make out what had happened in the darkness, the warriors of the Inner Palace shouted again.

“This is your final warning! Disarm yourself and surrender!”

“Put both hands over your head! Otherwise, I’ll put an arrow through your skull!”

“…”

That was a pretty savage script. Was this what they called a local patch?

I smacked my lips at the Nanman version of the NYPD and raised both hands as instructed. Once they knew who I was, the misunderstanding would clear up quickly. A few excuses, and that would be that.

Making more trouble would only make things harder for me…

Why are they looking at me like that?

They look as though they've seen a ghost.

Then I realized.

Fwoosh.

A breeze blew in from somewhere. My lower half felt unusually cool tonight.

Fwoosh.

"A-ah…!"

"Good heavens…!"

Dozens of torches shone on me like spotlights.

As the warriors forgot their duties long enough to gasp, I had one thought.

I'm really fucked.

I'd forgotten to pull up my pants.

"I'm asking because I genuinely want to know."

Namho, whom I met about half a shichen[2866] later, spoke with perfect composure.

"You bastard. Are you Dark Heaven?"

"…"

"You keep doing this because you're Dark Heaven, don't you? Huh?"

"…"

"Of course you are. What else could you be? Why would a Murim Alliance pavilion master come all the way to Nanman, punch a Great Chieftain in the solar plexus, then climb onto a pavilion in the middle of the night with his lower half on display? You came here determined to wreck the alliance admission from the start, didn't you? Am I wrong?"

Taishan, who was sitting at the table chewing something, shot up a hand.

"Namho, what is Dark Heaven? Taishan is curious."

Namho gave Taishan a long, searching look before turning to Sama Pyo.

"I'm asking you from the bottom of my heart. How do I put a padlock on that goddamn bastard's mouth?"

"Hmm."

After a moment's thought, Sama Pyo stood.

"I'll get more food."

"Good idea. But as an agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion with a keen eye, let me add this: don't bring the food here. Take him to it. If I hear one more word of his bullshit, I might go insane."

"…"

[2866] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

"…"

Namho was prickly even on a good day. Today, he was all sharp edges. Even oblivious Taishan looked frightened enough to apologize.

"Taishan… was wrong…"

Namho shot him a murderous glare, then steadied his breathing.

I knew my turn was coming and spoke first.

"Well… there's been a bit of a misunderstanding."

"A misunderstanding? What kind of dogshit misunderstanding?"

"Could you not put it like that? Just hear me out…"

"I heard everything! I heard every last bit of it! There are even witnesses! More than two hundred people saw it! Did you send Young Lady Ju here for this? Is that your thing?"

"Wow, come to think of it, it would've been awful if Young Lady Ju had been there. Thank God she wasn't…"

"You little baaastard!"

Boom! Crack!

That old man was over eighty, but he sure was strong. He had smashed apart that sturdy table with one blow.

I barely stopped myself from applauding. One more provocation, and Namho looked liable to die of rage.

"Elder Nam, calm down. Calm down," Sama Pyo said.

"Huff. Hah."

"Deep breath in, then out. Good. Just like that."

After soothing Namho with a look of concern that hardly suited a man of the unorthodox faction, Sama Pyo turned to me.

"Anyway, Pavilion Master, is what you just said true?"

"Yeah, damn it. There was a small misunderstanding I can't exactly tell other people about…"

"Did you really send Young Lady Ju here for this?"

"You fucking bastard."

How had things ended up like this? At this rate, my nickname would change to the *Naked Divine Dragon*.

I stared at the ceiling in despair, then finally managed to speak.

"That's not it. I was attacked before any of that happened."

"What?"

"Attacked?"

"Oh. Taishan knows what an attack is."

All three of them focused on me at once. Namho's eyes widened.

“When? Where?”

“In the latrine. I was doing my business when an arrow came flying in from outside. I ran out to find whoever shot it, and that’s how I ended up like this. I didn’t even have time to pull up my pants.”

“Then the culprit! Did you catch him?”

“Do you think I did? It was shot from far away, and there were so many people in the Inner Palace that I failed to find him.”

A dagger or poisoned needle would have made things easier. Hidden weapons like those had a much shorter range.

A bow could strike from quite a distance. That made the culprit much harder to find.

“Then why didn’t you say so from the start?” Namho demanded. “If you’d been attacked, you could have reported it to the Palace Lord immediately and had the culprit hunted down.”

He had a point. I’d considered telling them the truth. It would have been better than letting everyone think I was a pervert wandering around at night with his pants off.

But…

“Someone did shoot an arrow at me. I just don’t think it was an attack.”

“What?”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Taishan knows attacks. Taishan does not know attacks that are not attacks. Explain it to Taishan.”

“Die. Please die.”

Having shut Taishan down, Namho frowned at me.

“It wasn’t an attack?”

“Yes.”

“Then there was something hidden. Tell me in more detail.”

“I didn’t notice until later, but there was something strange attached to the arrow.”

As I answered, I spread my Qi Sense over a wide area. Once I was sure no one else was nearby, I silently gave another command.

Open Inventory. Summon.

Ding.

Something settled into my hand. I drew the hand I’d kept tucked inside my robes back out, bringing with it the arrow that had flown into the latrine. Then I untied the small leather pouch hanging from its fletching.

The rolled-up leather unfurled across the table. Smaller than a child’s palm, it bore letters as tiny as sesame seeds.

> Today. Insi[2867]. West Gate.

It was a missive—an invitation from someone whose identity I didn’t know.

[2867] Insi is the traditional time period from three to five in the morning.

Chapter 650

The banquet held in the Inner Palace alongside the Tribal Grand Council that day didn't begin to wind down until nearly the Ox hour.[2868]

For me, that was a relief. Otherwise, I'd have had to endure the stares and whispers coming from every direction all night.

"That Han Chinese fellow—wasn't he up on a pavilion with his pants off?"

"What? What are you talking about?"

"My wife's nephew is with the Inner Palace guard. Apparently, that brief alert a shichen[2869] ago was because of him."

"Now that you mention it, I did hear a whistle… But wasn't that when he said he was going to take a leak?"

"Maybe he didn't go take a leak. Maybe he wanted to show everyone something else. People have all kinds of tastes, you know. Could be a Central Plains custom."

"Good heavens. I had no idea the Central Plains had such a barbaric custom."

"Barbaric as it gets. But separate from that, he does seem pretty impressive."

"What does?"

"You know. That."

"Ah…"

"According to my nephew, they nearly attacked him because they thought he was holding a weapon. Until they shone a torch on him, they thought it was a spear."

"What? How could anyone mistake it for a spear?"

"Come now. Do you think 'dragon' was added to his sobriquet for no reason? A dragon is a dragon."

"Whaaaaaat!"

SYSTEM

Rumors about you are spreading far and wide!
A considerable number of influential figures are reacting to the rumors!
Fame has increased slightly!
Fame has increased slightly!

"…"

Please stop. And why did my Fame have to go up again?

My fucking life…

[2868] The Ox hour is a traditional time period from one to three in the morning.

[2869] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

I did my best to ignore the whispers around me as I tipped back the last of my drink. Seeing me like that, the Beast Miao King laughed heartily and patted me on the shoulder.

"Don't take it so hard. These things happen to a man."

"When you put it like that, it sounds like I did it on purpose. It was an accident. I was in such a hurry to get out that I forgot to fasten my trousers…"

"Hm? Why were you in such a hurry?"

"Ah, well…"

Damn it. That had slipped out.

I still hadn't told even the Beast Miao King about the missive from the unidentified sender. After a brief silence, I gave up.

"Actually, I did do it on purpose."

"Oh my."

"I've been like that since I was young. Still do it now and then."

"Good grief."

"It's my hobby and my special talent. You thought I only used one spear? I actually use two."

"Whaaaaaat…"

If I died in Nanman, it wouldn't matter how it happened. The cause of death would be humiliation.

But I couldn't tell him the truth. Whoever had contacted me this way wanted to meet in secret, which meant I wasn't supposed to tell anyone else.

At the very least, no one in the Nanman Beast Palace can know.

I trusted the Beast Miao King. But nowhere were *trust* and *faith* cheaper words than in Murim. No one knew what might happen.

Besides, if the Beast Miao King found out, someone else might notice.

That man, for instance.

I met Baeksang's impassive gaze. The longer I looked at him, the less I could read in his eyes.

He had spent the entire banquet sitting without lifting a finger to touch the food or alcohol. Now, after meeting my gaze, he smoothed his immaculate white robes, rose from his seat, and spoke.

"Palace Lord, it is already late. Let us end the banquet here."

"Hm. Let us."

The Beast Miao King nodded without hesitation. The Tribal Grand Council would continue tomorrow, after all.

Of course, since everyone present was a Peak master who practiced martial arts, none of them would suffer from a hangover. Even so, drinking in an atmosphere like this was bound to dull the mind.

Drip. Drip.

The Beast Miao King expelled the alcohol through his fingertips. His face clear again, he announced the end of the banquet, drawing disappointed murmurs from around the room.

Not any of them, then. The appointed time is nearly here, and they're disappointed the banquet's ending.

After quickly checking the faces of those who looked disappointed, I spoke to the Beast Miao King.

"Sir Yayul, I should head in too."

"Of course. Which pavilion will you be going to this time?"

"…"

Seriously?

He took one look at my face, slapped his knee, and laughed. I sighed and left with Namho and the rest of the unorthodox faction underlings.

By then, the night had deepened, and the time had entered Insi.[2870]

It was time to meet whoever had sent the missive.

"Are you sure you'll be all right going alone? It could be a trap."

On the way to the quarters assigned to the Fire Dragon Pavilion, I reassured the worried-looking Namho.

"I'll be fine. Besides, Elder Nam, you'd only be a burden if you came."

"…"

"Were you thinking of following me?"

"I've lived a fairly long life, but I have no desire to die like a stray dog."

"Then stay in the quarters with the other two deadweights."

Taishan, as usual, gave it little thought. Sama Pyo was less pleased to be called deadweight when he was one of the unorthodox faction's finest young prodigies, but my next words shut him up.

"If you don't like it, reach Supreme Peak."

"…"

"I can somehow survive, but you two can't. Keep watch around the quarters until I return. And swing your swords at least one more time while you're at it."

We went inside together as though nothing were amiss. Fifteen minutes later, I slipped out unnoticed and disappeared into the darkness.

Around Insi.[2871] The West Gate, right?

[2870] Insi is the traditional time period from three to five in the morning.

[2871] Insi is the traditional time period from three to five in the morning.

I had no idea whether the contents of the missive tied to the arrow were a trap or an attempt to make contact in order to share information. I could only go and find out for myself.

Whoosh, whoosh!

I kept out of sight of the patrolling warriors as I moved. Before long, the cheers and clamor that had echoed faintly in the distance grew louder.

Fwoosh! Boom!

"Waaaaaaah!"

The banquet in the Inner Palace was over, but the night's festivities in the Outer Palace were still going strong. They would go on tomorrow and the day after, too.

The ordinary tribespeople—neither the chieftains attending the Tribal Grand Council nor the warriors standing guard—were completely immersed in the festival atmosphere.

So that's why the meeting place is in the Outer Palace. It's more crowded now than at any other time of year.

I slipped into the crowd. The streets were packed with people wearing animal masks, and no one gave me a second look in the tiger mask I'd worn before.

The West Gate… Is that over there?

The Outer Palace was in a festive mood, but its guards hadn't let their vigilance slip. I avoided the warriors stationed along the way and soon reached the West Gate.

Or, more precisely, somewhere near it. The area was just as crowded as the rest of the Outer Palace.

I came where the missive told me to, but…

There were too many people here, and plenty of guards besides. If I stood around like a Great General guardian post,[2872] I was bound to draw attention.

What now?

I was looking around when someone called out.

"Hey, tiger-mask fellow. If you've got nothing better to do, come have a bowl of somyeon[2873] before you go."

I turned toward the voice and met the eyes of a middle-aged man at a nearby food stall. His face and eyes were unremarkable, and he was painfully thin. He grinned and raised the bowl in front of him.

"I don't usually talk to strangers, but the broth here is incredible."

"…Hm."

I wasn't sure the broth was the only incredible thing here.

[2872] "Great General of All Under Heaven" is an inscription on a Korean village guardian post, traditionally erected to stand watch at an entrance.

[2873] Somyeon is a dish of thin wheat noodles served here in broth.

I studied him for the briefest moment, then nodded and sat beside him. At last, I sent a thread of Sound Transmission to the unexpected contact.

—Funny. You've lost a lot of weight in a short time. You seemed to be eating plenty at the banquet.

"…!"

Clatter!

His thin body flinched and trembled. I picked up the chopsticks he had dropped and continued the Sound Transmission.

—So what brings the Great Chieftain of the Yi people here?

Heugung's eyes widened at the Sound Transmission in his ear.

Heugung was clearly shocked that I'd recognized him so quickly, but I was no less surprised.

He sent the missive?

We hadn't met often or spent much time together, but I'd already formed an opinion of him: a pathetic man so besotted with Yohi's beauty that he'd hand over his liver and gallbladder, and a spineless puppet who followed Baeksang's lead.

Perhaps that was why this surprised me so much. Neither his appearance nor his behavior matched the man I thought I knew. And that magnificent spare tire you could have made a pilgrimage around? Gone without a trace.

If not for the System, he'd have fooled me completely.

I marveled inwardly and put the chopsticks back in his hand, adding a casual remark for anyone who might be watching.

"Why'd you drop these all of a sudden? Feeling weak?"

Heugung came to his senses and hurriedly composed himself.

"Ah, thank you."

Only the two of us knew that Sound Transmissions were passing beneath our ordinary conversation.

"Sir, one bowl of somyeon,[2874] please."

I placed my order, then moved my lips.

—You sent the missive tied to the arrow, didn't you?

When the hunched old owner didn't stir, Heugung pounded on the stall.

"Sir! One bowl of somyeon!"[2875]

He grinned at me.

[2874] Somyeon is a dish of thin wheat noodles served here in broth.

[2875] Somyeon is a dish of thin wheat noodles served here in broth.

“You’ll have to excuse him. He’s over ninety, and his hearing isn’t what it used to be.”

—…Yes, I sent it. But I changed my appearance with the Bone-Shrinking Technique. How did you recognize me at a glance?

Ah. The Bone-Shrinking Technique.

That answered one question about his sudden transformation.

Jeok Cheongang had once told me it was a martial art that could stretch and shrink bone and flesh like rubber bands. Learning it was so difficult and painful that almost no one in the Central Plains practiced it.

I doubt it’s common in Nanman either.

I still had plenty of questions. While I waited for the somyeon,[2876] I spoke aloud.

“I was craving some hot broth anyway. This worked out nicely.”

—How I recognized you doesn’t matter. Why send that missive?

Heugung made sure I had chopsticks as he answered.

“If nothing else, the broth is excellent. He’s been running this stall almost as long as he’s been alive.”

—I had information I absolutely needed to tell you.

“Oh, really? Then I’ll look forward to it.”

—Were you trying to kill me or tell me something? I nearly ended up with an arrow through my head.

—I thought you’d dodge it. Even Great Chieftain Baeksang couldn’t get the better of you. Surely you could dodge one arrow.

“…”

Did he have any idea that arrow was how I’d become the Naked Divine Dragon?

I considered smacking him over the head, but generously restrained myself.

—So, what is this information you absolutely had to tell me?

Heugung stared at the bowl steaming in front of him. His lips moved with difficulty.

—Great Chieftain Baeksang… has colluded with Dark Heaven.

“…!”

Crack.

My grip tightened before I knew it, and the chopsticks snapped in my hand.

[2876] Somyeon is a dish of thin wheat noodles served here in broth.

Chapter 651

There are plenty of things in this world that suspicion alone can't settle.

That's true of the twenty-first century I'd lived in all my life, and just as true of Murim, which might as well be lawless by comparison.

Especially when the person in question stands second only to one man and above ten thousand others in the vast land of Nanman.

But…

—Great Chieftain Baeksang has colluded with Dark Heaven.

"…!"

Well, that changed things.

I set down the chopsticks I'd snapped without realizing it. The old stall owner grumbled at the sight, but all my attention was on Heugung.

—Are you certain?

—I am. No… at least, I believe I am.

What?

I barely stopped myself from frowning.

—That sounds like you have no concrete evidence. "I believe I am" isn't enough for this. You have to be certain.

—B-but…

Heugung swallowed hard before continuing his Sound Transmission.

—This is the best I can tell you. Great Chieftain Baeksang keeps that many secrets. I lead one of Nanman's four great tribes myself, but… he never discusses anything important with me in depth.

It lasted only an instant, but I caught the emotion that crossed his face at those last words. It was unmistakably humiliation.

Perhaps it had been piling up inside him for a very long time.

I studied him, then moved my lips.

—Is that why?

—Why? What do you mean?

—Is that why you betrayed the man you followed, sent me a secret missive, and told me all this? Because of how you feel about Baeksang?

—B-betrayed him? That's…

—If this isn't betrayal, then I'm not Han Chinese—I'm from Nanman. Don't bother denying it.

As if I had hit the mark, Heugung bit his lip hard and gave a small nod.

—Fine. I won't deny it. Ever since my father died in the Great Faction War, I've lived under Great Chieftain Baeksang's shadow. I was a runny-nosed child then,

and I'm still under it now. No—I should say he's dragged me around on an invisible leash. But that isn't the only reason I decided to meet you.

—Then what is?

—I want to protect Nanman. My people.

—…!

—The Great Chieftain Baeksang I've known has always been coolheaded and capable. That's why he'll never back down. He'll believe the choice he made was right. But if this goes on… Nanman is finished.

I silently stared at Heugung.

How much of this secret conversation at a little stall on a crowded street was I supposed to believe?

Can I trust him?

My doubts weren't limited to what he'd told me. They extended to Heugung himself, who had suddenly arranged this secret meeting.

In some ways, trusting him mattered more than anything else. If I couldn't do that, how could I trust the details he hadn't told me yet?

He's seemed sincere so far. But what if it's all an act?

Murim was a fierce, unpredictable place. Heroes, Third Rate thugs, fiends, hypocrites—every kind of person was mixed together, deceiving and being deceived, drawing hidden blades to stab one another in the back.

Nothing would surprise me here.

As I weighed the situation, the old stall owner broke the silence.

Clack.

Setting down the bowl seemed to take all his strength. His hand trembled, and broth spilled over the rim.

The cheap somyeon,[2877] worth only a few iron coins, lay tangled in the bowl. Rather like the thoughts in my head.

"Finally. Try the broth first. That's the best part."

Heugung tried to sound cheerful, but his eyes darted around the street.

—Be careful. Great Chieftain Baeksang has eyes and ears you won't see. I need to return within half an hour if I'm to avoid suspicion.

—Did you slip away while you were with him?

—No. But there's always someone nearby watching me. A plant put in place long ago to track my movements. Today should be safe, though.

He didn't name the person who'd planted that watcher. He didn't have to.

Baeksang.

[2877] Somyeon is a thin wheat noodle commonly served in broth.

Sitting there staring at steaming somyeon would only attract attention. I started eating and sent another Sound Transmission.

—How long have you been watched?

—I don’t know. I first noticed it around the time I came of age. I’ve been wary of Great Chieftain Baeksang for more than twenty years since. That’s why I secretly learned the Bone-Shrinking Technique. It’s difficult to master, but unlike other martial arts, the training leaves almost no trace.

I had to revise my opinion of him.

Not bad.

It was ridiculous for me to judge a man well past forty like that, but he was nothing like the fool who’d been grinning at everyone a few hours ago.

So he found his own way to survive.

His sudden approach still gave me reason to be suspicious. But the more I heard, the more I believed him. The somyeon tasting far better than I’d expected probably helped, too.

Slurp.

I finished the rich broth, took a few iron coins from my robes, and set them beside the empty bowl. Then I stood and patted Heugung’s shoulder. He looked startled.

“You were right. The broth here is good.”

“I-I’m glad you liked it. But where are you going…?”

“Why? I’ve eaten, so it’s time to get moving. You look like you’ve got somewhere to be, too. Don’t you?”

His eyes widened slightly. He must have heard the Sound Transmission I’d sent along with the words.

—Follow me. Slowly. Keep your distance.

The somyeon had taken care of the appetizer. Now for the main course.

—Tell me everything you’ve seen and heard at Baeksang’s side.

The street was so crowded there was barely room to walk.

Heugung and I slipped into the throng and moved slowly, keeping about ten feet between us. Now and then we watched fireworks burst overhead or turned our heads to look along the street. Our Sound Transmissions, though, stayed fixed on one subject.

—Let me get straight to it. Have you seen anything that points to Baeksang colluding with Dark Heaven?

—I have no concrete evidence. But from what I’ve observed, I’m certain of it.

—Without evidence, that isn’t enough.

—I couldn’t help it. Until now, I’ve lived like livestock inside a fence Great Chieftain Baeksang built around me.

—Then when did you begin to suspect him, and why?

—Being raised inside a fence didn’t mean I could never look outside it. I may lead the Yi people in name only, but I’m still their great chieftain. I was occasionally present when Baeksang met with others. Or perhaps he simply thought I wasn’t worth worrying about. He wouldn’t have been wrong.

His Sound Transmission took on a self-mocking edge.

—Do you know what sort of man Great Chieftain Baeksang is? Or what you know of the Bai people?

—I don’t know much about Nanman, but I’ve heard various things from a reliable source. I’ve also formed a certain judgment of Baeksang myself.

—An opinion. Interesting.

—What’s interesting about it?

—Simple. I’ve known him since I was very young, yet I’ve had to revise my opinion of him again and again. The older I got and the more I understood, the more often it happened.

—…!

—That’s the kind of man he is. Dense forests, deep swamps, every sort of treacherous ground—this land doesn’t let secrets escape. For instance…

He trailed off.

The next moment, I felt someone’s gaze and turned my head. Heugung’s eyes met mine, shining brightly.

—The finest Bai warriors, waiting for the right moment in a secret refuge somewhere in Nanman even now.

My feet stopped before I could help it. I turned toward a nearby stall as naturally as I could and moved my lips.

—Go on.

—Have I told you about my father? He was a respected great chieftain and an outstanding warrior. The loyal men who followed him helped me at the cost of their lives. Their sacrifice is how I learned of that refuge.

—Do you know exactly where it is?

—I did. Twenty years ago.

—…Twenty years ago?

—The only thing that came back that day was a messenger pigeon carrying a missive written in blood. None of my father’s men returned. A few days later, I went to the location in the message, using a hunt for ferocious beasts as my excuse. I saw the mountain engulfed in flames before I even reached its foot.

—…!

—The fire burned for a month and seven days. When it finally died, nothing remained but ashes. Strange, isn't it?

His Sound Transmission turned bitter.

—Every time one of my loyal retainers died, I learned something new. Great Chieftain Baeksang exchanges missives to unknown destinations on the first day of every month, between Insi and the hour of the Rabbit.[2878] He also disappears somewhere alone once every three months… Ah, since last year, that changed to once a month. The person who followed him then was the last subordinate I could trust. I never saw him again after that.

A heavy silence settled between us.

All around us, people chatted and cheered. Heugung and I didn't join them.

Baeksang and Dark Heaven. Dark Heaven and Baeksang. And…

Heugung.

Which parts were true? Which were lies?

My thoughts were hazy, as though I had been swallowed by Poison Mist.

Yet beyond that haze, I could still make out the figure I'd followed with my eyes and thoughts from the beginning.

Baeksang.

And then there was someone else who had yet to appear.

A name came to mind. I sent Heugung another Sound Transmission.

—What about the other person?

—Other person? Who?

—The other great chieftain. Yohi.

—…!

—I've been wondering why you haven't said a word about her.

Through the passing crowd, I saw his gaunt frame jerk. His gaze met mine, trembling faintly.

—She hasn't done anything wrong.

—What?

—She only made the wrong choice. All she wanted was to restore the Yao people…

His voice gradually faded.

I blinked blankly at Heugung, and the back of my head began to tingle.

Fuck. Don't tell me…

—Wait. That wasn't an act? You really like Yohi?

—I don't like her. I love her.

—Sorry, but are you out of your fucking mind?

[2878] Insi is the traditional time period from three to five in the morning; the hour of the Rabbit follows it, from five to seven.

—…

This was driving me crazy.

I had suspected as much, but all those foolish grins whenever Yohi appeared had really been genuine.

He had even put up a soul shield strong enough to make Magic Johnson cry.

I barely managed to restrain myself from pushing through the crowd and marching over to him. Instead, I sent a Sound Transmission that was almost a shout.

—Would you say that in front of Sir Yayul, too? That Yohi did nothing wrong?

—That's why I came to you. First, I didn't think the Palace Lord would trust me over Great Chieftain Baeksang. Second, I thought he wouldn't forgive our Yohi.

—Wow. Listen to this "our Yohi" bullshit.

—…!

—Ah, sorry. But you really are an idiot. Anyway, I understand now. Your Yohi defected to that side.

Heugung's face stiffened at my choice of words. He opened his mouth as if to object, then sighed.

—I made up my mind before coming here. If you and the Palace Lord want me to, I'll testify at tomorrow's Tribal Grand Council. But you must promise to protect both Yohi and me.

The first offer was good. The second sat badly with me.

Neither was mine to accept on the spot. Protecting Heugung was one thing; protecting Yohi would practically mean pardoning a defector. I wasn't Syngman Rhee taking in pro-Japanese collaborators.[2879] How could I decide that alone? At best, I was the U.N. forces.

But if the Beast Miao King agrees…

If Heugung's words were true, we could not only root out Dark Heaven's threat from Nanman, but might even drag the Nanman Beast Palace into the Murim Alliance as one enormous headache.

If he was telling the truth.

—This had better be true. Every word.

Fsssh!

I sent a wave of qi bearing down on Heugung alone. His face went pale under the force of it, and his lips moved.

—My life. I stake my life on it.

I held his gaze a moment longer, then withdrew my aura.

[2879] Syngman Rhee is criticized for allowing many collaborators with Imperial Japan to retain influence in South Korea after liberation.

He stood panting, glanced around, gave a small nod, and disappeared into the crowd. The half hour he'd warned me about had passed.

"…Phew."

Only then did I take a full breath and start walking. Before I told the Beast Miao King, I wanted to stop at our quarters and talk it over with the Fire Dragon Pavilion members.

Those damn men. I'll consider it a success if they haven't caused any trouble.

Sama Pyo had come out to the clearing in front of the quarters to train when a thought occurred to him.

Was he simply born unlucky, or had the karma from that damn Pavilion Master's misdeeds flowed all the way here like a stream?

"So let me ask you."

Shing.

The Black Dragon Saber slid free with a cold ring. Sama Pyo stepped forward, his favored weapon in hand.

"What do you lot think?"

Rustle.

The grass around the clearing shook.

Chapter 652

Rustle.

Sama Pyo knew it wasn't a passing breeze stirring the thick grass.

The killing intent of dozens of enemies pointed at him like invisible blades.

"You show up uninvited, and when I ask a question, you don't answer…"

Unwelcome guests didn't get much worse than this.

He clicked his tongue and let his Black Dragon Saber hang at his side.

"Come out. We can at least talk face-to-face."

A dozen or so throwing blades came in reply.

Whoosh! Clang!

Sama Pyo knocked them aside with a lightning-fast swing of his saber and turned smoothly on his heel. Saber energy wrapped around the dark blade, then swept through the grass like a gale.

Sh-sh-sh-shk! Slash!

Hundreds of leaves flew apart in pieces. A faint line appeared across the trunk of a massive tree.

Sss, crash!

The giant tree slid to the ground. Sama Pyo vaulted over it and stared at the figures approaching the clearing.

East, west, north, south. Roughly thirty enemies moved slowly into position around the pavilion. Every one of them wore a black mask.

"Hard to get a look at your faces. When you come uninvited, the polite thing would be to take off your masks and apologize… but I doubt you're going to do that."

Sama Pyo took stock of the situation calmly.

Masked intruders at this hour of the night, greeting him with throwing blades. Their purpose could hardly have been clearer.

Worse…

Of all times, this had to happen while he was away.

He thought of that Pavilion Master bastard, with a mouth as foul as a Third Rate thug's and a habit of punching someone whenever the chance arose.

Jin Taekyung.

The man was impossible to predict and forever causing trouble. But in a situation like this, there was no one Sama Pyo would trust more. At only twenty-two, he had already left his mark on Murim—a monster of a man.

But whether by coincidence or fate, Jin Taekyung was currently away. Song Ilseom and Ju Hwaran, who would have been a great help if they had remained, were absent as well. Hyuk Mujin was gone, too—although he might not have been able to match them, he was at least worth one person.

That left Sama Pyo, Taishan—who had gone to bed early—and Namho, an ordinary old man against whom Sama Pyo couldn't use his full strength.

Against nearly thirty enemies.

No. Their numbers aren't the problem.

Sama Pyo muttered inwardly and quickly swept his gaze across the surroundings. The killing intent radiating from the enemies slowly tightening around him like a net was not that of some clumsy martial artists.

By Central Plains standards, each of them is somewhere between Supreme First Rate and Peak. Where in Nanman did they come from?

The Central Plains Murim was truly vast, but even among the countless martial artists scattered across it like grains of sand on a beach, Peak masters were not common.

Yet in Nanman, which could not compare to the Central Plains, someone had mobilized thirty warriors of this caliber to launch an attack.

Fortunately, none seemed to be at a particularly high level. Still, their presence was startling—especially because this remote stretch of land belonged to the Inner Palace of the Nanman Beast Palace.

"Who are you?"

Whoosh! Crack!

Instead of an answer, a short spear skimmed past his neck and smashed through the pavilion door.

That was the signal to begin.

Papapat!

Hidden weapons and arrows flew in, blotting out the faint moonlight. Shadows rushed forward like streaks of light.

Sama Pyo's Black Dragon Saber cut through the wind.

Whiiiiing! Slash!

Powerful saber energy swept the projectiles aside. The instant he broke through the barrage, blades lunged for him from left and right.

Whoosh!

Neither attacker hesitated to strike at his vitals. Their movements were timed perfectly together. An ordinary Peak master would have been badly wounded, if not killed.

But Sama Pyo was no ordinary Peak master.

He was not a young prodigy lacking real combat experience, nor was he as rigid as a Peak master from an orthodox faction.

Above all else, demonic, heterodox arts valued survival.

Click, crunch!

The two Peak masters attacking from either side crumpled like rotten trees.

Their eyes stared wide above their masks. A small arrow, a span long, was buried deep between each man's brows.

It worked.

There was a simple reason Sama Pyo wore a thin robe instead of a lighter martial uniform in this heat: its full sleeves gave him room to hide weapons.

Twist his wrist to the right angle, and the mechanism fired a loaded arrow. It was simple, but against an enemy who didn't expect it, few things were deadlier.

"Idiots."

He pulled the falling bodies toward him and held one in front of himself, the other behind.

Thud-thud-thud!

A fresh volley of hidden weapons struck the men who had been the attackers' allies moments before, riddling their corpses. From behind his makeshift shields, Sama Pyo aimed his sleeve past the side of one body.

Click, thud!

This time, the enemy knew what to watch for. The arrow struck a forearm instead of the space between the brows he had aimed for.

He had shown them the trick twice. It wouldn't work again.

Then…

Snap.

Sama Pyo made his decision at once. He released the mechanism hidden in his sleeve and charged, shouting as he went.

"Taishan!"

Sh-sh-sh-shk!

The remaining twenty-seven masked men closed around him like wolves.

Bang!

Namho had finally fallen asleep after a long stretch of tossing and turning. The instant he opened his eyes, one thought came to him.

What fucking bastard is this?

Growing old came with no end of indignities. One of the cruelest was how little sleep he got at night.

And now someone had dared to disturb what sleep this eighty-year-old could manage. His joints creaked as he sat up.

If that gluttonous bastard Taishan woke me up because he was eating a midnight snack… this time, I absolutely will not let it slide.

He had spent fifty years in the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, whatever anyone might think to look at him. After everything he had sacrificed during the Great Faction

War, the Thousand-Faced Fox might overlook it just this once if Namho wrote to Henan and had Taishan declared an enemy of Murim.

Would he believe me if I said the bastard worked for Dark Heaven?

The thought vanished when he heard the commotion outside.

"Taishan!"

Sh-sh-sh-shk! Clang!

Cha-cha-cha-chang!

Namho stared down at the clearing through the window. He rubbed his eyes, wondering if he was seeing things.

He wasn't. An enemy's Sword Energy, dodged by Sama Pyo, swept past Namho's window.

Slash! Crash!

At last, he understood.

An ambush!

A planned one, too. They had struck while that madman—no, while Jin Taekyung—was away.

What the hell is going on? Who would…?

Being woken up no longer bothered him. In a moment, he might lose his head instead of his sleep.

Sama Pyo was fighting better than Namho had expected, but he couldn't hold out against so many enemies forever.

And then—

Papapat!

When Namho spotted several masked men approaching the pavilion while leaving Sama Pyo behind, he no longer had even a moment to hesitate.

"Gah!"

Namho bolted from his room with a speed that belied his eighty years. He raced down the corridor and flung open the door at its end.

Bang!

"Ambush! We're under attack! Your lord is outside—!"

Taishan, the room's occupant, answered with a mighty roar.

"Grrrrrrrk. Hooooooonk!"

"You damn bastard!"

"Guh-hooooooonk!"

Namho couldn't believe it.

He can sleep through this? Is he even human?

Parts of the pavilion were breaking apart. The clash of weapons was loud enough to be heard in Henan. Yet here Taishan lay inside it, snoring.

"You! Wake up this instant!"

Thud! Thud-thud!

With a soul-rending cry, Namho's fist—its strength diminished by the passing years—slammed into Taishan's jaw.

As though heaven had been moved by his efforts, Taishan finally stirred.

"Mmm. Taishan…"

"Yes! Get up! Hurry!"

"Mmmm. Don't like mosquitoes. Go away…"

"You son of a bitch!"

It came out almost as a wail.

Tears were gathering in Namho's eyes when a dark shadow fell across the floor in the moonlight streaming through the open window.

"…"

He froze.

Slowly, he turned his head. Three masked men had slipped into the pavilion.

Those… those bastards.

They moved like ghosts. Their weapons flashed white in the moonlight, and Namho's eighty-odd years rushed before his eyes.

Then he realized there was one way to wake Taishan.

"Taishan! You bastard!"

Sss.

The masked men raised their weapons as Namho shouted. Thinking of death, Namho squeezed his eyes shut and continued yelling.

"They're going to eat all your meat!"

In the next instant—

"No! Taishan's meat!"

Taishan's eyes flew open as if by magic. He thrust a fist toward the masked men.

Wham! Krrrra-boom!

Hoo. Hah.

Sama Pyo fought to steady his breathing.

Blood soaked his upper body. The masked men watching him now had a trace of fear in their eyes.

He had fought more fiercely and brutally than they had imagined, with hidden weapons and poisons concealed all over his body and martial arts honed for one purpose: killing.

More frightening still, he showed no fear of death.

"Come on, any of you. I swear I'll give everything I have to kill you."

He charged them, panting, covered in blood. One by one, masked men fell beneath his hands.

Twenty bodies lay scattered across the ground. Seven of them belonged to Peak masters who would have been recognized anywhere in the Central Plains.

What a monster.

The same thought struck the masked men at once.

"No! Taishan's meat!"

Crack! Krrrra-boom!

A real monster burst out of the collapsing pavilion.

Eight cheok[2880] tall, with an enormous frame. And…

"Taishan's meat! Where's the meat?"

A madness that seemed to belong to another world.

Gulp.

What the hell is that?

As the masked men swallowed hard, a small old man poked his head out from behind the giant and pointed at them.

"See those men?"

"Taishan sees them!"

"I saw everything earlier, and those bastards ate all your meat."

"Taishaaaaaan! Cannot forgive them!"

What meat? What were they supposed to have stolen and eaten?

The bewildered masked men faltered. Sama Pyo bared his bloodstained teeth in a grin.

But he wasn't looking at Taishan. He was looking at the hill above the clearing—or, rather, at someone ambling down it.

"I had a feeling this might happen even while I was away for a little while."

Step. Step.

Jin Taekyung approached at an easy pace and asked Sama Pyo, "Are those your friends?"

Sama Pyo burst out laughing and shook his head.

[2880] A *cheok* is a traditional Korean unit of length, about 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Eight cheok is about 2.42 m (7.95 ft).

Chapter 653

"Are those your friends?"

Sama Pyo laughed aloud before answering in a weary voice.

"As if."

"Yeah, you do seem to be on pretty bad terms for friends."

I scratched my chin and slowly looked around.

The already ancient pavilion had collapsed. Blood stained the weeds that grew thick across the clearing.

All right. Situation assessed.

What a complete fucking mess.

I'd only been away from our quarters a little while, and now there were some twenty corpses to clean up. We could have used a snail bride to handle that.[2881] Instead, we'd gotten snail assassins in the middle of the night.

I glanced at the assassins who had faltered when I appeared, then shrugged at Sama Pyo.

"Oh, you're better than I thought."

Blood drenched his upper body. He answered between ragged breaths.

"Yeah, I'm not bad. For an unorthodox goon."

Honestly, I was starting to feel bad calling him that. He'd been badly outnumbered by skilled enemies, and fighting this hard against them meant he'd truly put his life on the line.

Impressed, I nodded.

"You've done enough that I can't keep calling you an unorthodox goon… From now on, you're an unorthodox hardcase."

"An unorthodox hardcase. How kind of you."

"Oh, you're grateful? That's a surprise. I thought you'd start cursing me as soon as you heard it."

"Cursing takes energy. I'm about to collapse, so stop talking to me."

His honesty drew a quiet laugh from me.

"Then collapse."

"What?"

"I said collapse. Don't worry about the rest."

"Damn it. You could've said that sooner…"

His words trailed off as his eyes began to close. At the same time, Sama Pyo's body slowly tilted to the side, and I stepped toward him.

Whoosh. Thud.

[2881] A snail bride is a figure from a Korean folktale who secretly does housework.

The three-zhang[2882] gap vanished in an instant.

Just as I caught him before he could pitch face-first into the ground, a sharp whistle split the air and wind whipped up behind me.

Whoosh!

It happened behind me, but I could see it. No—I could sense and read everything through my sharpened instincts.

Now that I'd stepped into this space, it was practically my domain.

Crack!

Without turning, I threw a punch. Something shattered beneath my fist, and a masked man with his head crushed like tofu fell into a pool of blood.

Splash.

Sticky blood sprayed across my back. Ignoring it, I laid Sama Pyo on a relatively clean patch of ground and raised my head.

The masked men stood frozen like stone statues.

"Why are you just standing there? That was pretty much your last chance."

"…"

"…"

"What's so surprising? Were you planning to ding-dong ditch me, you fucking bastards?"

In the suffocating silence, the more than ten pairs of eyes visible above the masks shook violently.

Papap!

Whiiiiing!

A gale far fiercer than the first swept out in every direction.

Every masked man still standing was a Peak Master capable of injuring others with Sword Energy. Swords, sabers, spears, sickles… Destructive qi surged from their weapons, tearing through the air toward the vital points across my body.

I watched it all without the slightest fear.

The flow of qi. The direction of each weapon.

Even the faint fear in their wide eyes.

That settled it. They had already lost. They knew they were no more than wolves, yet they refused to accept it and charged at a tiger anyway.

Then I'd better teach them. Teach them that they should have run somehow.

Dozens of forms flashed through my mind. I chose the cruelest, most destructive one and moved.

Whoosh! Crunch!

[2882] A *zhang* is ten *ja*, a traditional length measure. Three zhang is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

I twisted smoothly aside. Four weapons missed me by a hair and tangled together as their paths crossed. I brought my straightened hand down through their center.

Slash!

Force cut the weapons apart. I struck one of the masked men in the abdomen as he stood frozen, still gripping what remained of his prized weapon.

Flame Divine Palm.

Boom!

Terrible heat burned away the life force inside his body. I lowered my head as he crumpled behind me, smoke pouring from his seven apertures.[2883]

Shaaak! Whoosh!

A strike had come from behind without warning. The long sickle meant to reap my neck swept through empty air, while my backward-thrust elbow struck its wielder square in the chest.

Crack!

More than a dozen ribs broke. He gave a dying gasp.

But my blow wasn't what killed him. His comrade's spear did.

Thrust!

Look at these bastards. Not a shred of comradeship.

Clicking my tongue, I seized the spearhead jutting from his chest and squeezed.

Crack!

He was a Peak Master who had reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy. I was a Supreme Peak master who had entered the realm of Sword Energy Becoming Force.

I snapped the spearhead off as easily as a wooden chopstick and returned it to its owner.

Whoosh! Thunk!

The result was instant death. The spearhead lodged between the masked man's brows, and he collapsed without a scream. His comrades swallowed their gasps. Three of them had died in less time than it took to call it a moment.

Seven left.

I counted them calmly and took a step.

Whoosh!

Space vanished with the wind, and another enemy appeared right in front of me. No—I was the one who had reached him.

"…"

His wide eyes seemed to be trying to say something. Too late. I tightened my grip around his neck.

[2883] The seven apertures are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

Crack!

Six.

I felt the life leave him as his body went limp. I took the sword from his hand and hurled it at the nearest enemy.

“Hng!”

With a panicked gasp, the man raised his curved moon saber diagonally. My sword flew straight into the saber, which was charged with saber qi.

Boom!

The ground heaved with a deafening roar. A staggering figure emerged from the billowing dust.

The moon saber had shattered against the qi in my sword. Dozens of fragments were embedded across its wielder’s body.

“Grrk. Grrr…”

Thud.

The largest fragment was lodged in his throat. Perhaps that was why he fell without even managing a last word, blood bubbling in his throat.

I pushed aside the corpse with the broken neck and spoke quietly.

“Five left.”

“…”

“…”

I could feel the fear filling the suffocating silence. Five Peak Masters had fallen in mere moments, and I didn’t have a scratch on me as I looked for my next target.

“Who’s next?”

No one answered.

Then the masked men, frozen in place and staring at me with eyes wide as if they had seen a ghost, chose to target someone else instead of me.

Papap!

Of the five, three went for me. The other two went for Namho and Taishan.

I had to admit, it was probably the best choice they could make. That didn’t mean it would end well for them.

“I saw it with my own eyes! Those bastards ate both chicken legs!”

“Legs? Not wings—legs? Both of them?”

Taishan blinked at Namho in disbelief, then drew the two-section staff from his side.

“Both chicken legs! Too far! You’re not human!”

We’d have needed a vote to settle who wasn’t human, but Taishan made voting irrelevant with his enormous two-section staff.

Wham! Crack!

His innate divine strength was enough to make a defense useless. One masked man instinctively raised his sword to block the staff. Both his wrists broke, and before he could scream, Taishan smashed his head along with the other man's.

Crack!

The two bodies hit the ground without so much as a dying cry.

From behind Taishan, Namho clenched a fist and shouted, "That's it! You commendable bastard, I could kill you!"

"Uaaaaaah! Taishan is commendable!"

"Well done, you goddamn bastard! All you ever do is eat, but you've finally earned your keep!"

I gave a quiet laugh at Namho's praise—or abuse; it was hard to tell—then turned to the remaining enemies.

"All right. Three left."

"…"

"…"

"…"

Their eyes twitched. They understood.

Even as their comrades died, they had been backing away, unable to bring themselves to attack me.

"I'm telling you this just in case, but if you run, you'll die. Of course, unlike your friends who went sightseeing at Mount Beimang first, you'll die much more painfully after lingering a long time before your breath finally stops."

At my quiet warning, someone's throat bobbed as he swallowed.

They'd all watched their comrades die. If they ran, they would end up wishing they'd died the same way.

"But surrender here and tell me what I want to know, and I'll keep you alive no matter what it takes. If you don't believe me, I'll stake my life on it."

I didn't want to spare men who had come here to do this. But I had to find out who was behind the ambush.

I named the people who came to mind, one by one.

"Baeksang. Heugung. Yohi. If one of them is your master, tell me now. If someone else sent you, tell me everything you know about them."

Who was it?

I had my suspicions, but I couldn't be certain. Only a handful of people were bold enough to stage an attack inside the Inner Palace, powerful enough to send warriors of this caliber, and well-informed enough to know I was gone.

It has to be one of the three Great Chieftains.

I'd moved so discreetly. How had anyone noticed? I didn't know who had found out, or how. The timing of the ambush was too perfect, too.

I couldn’t even rule out Heugung. We’d parted barely fifteen minutes ago, after he promised to cooperate.

Did he ask to meet me just so he could stab me in the back? Fool me first, then seize the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and use them to threaten me?

Or it could have been Baeksang, who had been watching Heugung, or Yohi.

One thing was certain: whatever name came from these masked attackers’ mouths would belong to a Dark Heaven hound.

“Who is it? Tell me.”

Ssssss.

I pressed down on them with an overwhelming wave of qi. The foreheads visible above their masks creased in pain.

Then, in the next moment, I saw the corners of the masked men’s mouths twitch.

Crunch.

“…!”

A chill swept over me. I hurriedly fired Finger Qi and struck their pressure points, but dark-red blood burst from the mouths of the men who had severed their own heart meridians.

“Grrrk. Cough.”

Fuck.

Chapter 654

If someone asked whether I could kill three Peak masters with a single move, I would nod without much hesitation.

But subduing three Peak masters in a single move was another matter, especially if they had the mindset of assassins.

In that case, persuasion was a better way to bring them under control than force. To stop them from killing themselves, I had to convince them they would survive—not that they would be tortured and die in agony.

But…

Crunch.

Apparently, my promise hadn't convinced them. Or perhaps they feared their master even more.

Ssshhh! Thud!

The Finger Qi I fired a half-beat too late struck their acupoints, but the damage was already done.

Their bodies went rigid as their Paralysis Acupoints were struck. Blood sprayed from their seven apertures, and all three began to collapse.

Papap! Grab.

I crossed several zhang[2884] in an instant, caught them, and laid them on the ground.

Sticky blood welled from their mouths beneath their masks.

"Grrrk, cough…!"

Damn it. This was bad. No, it was the worst possible outcome.

Severing your own heart meridian was like setting off an explosion inside your body.

If the Eight Extraordinary Meridians—the most important meridians in the human body—as well as the hundreds of acupoints throughout the body were severed and blocked, there was no way to survive.

Especially for a Murim practitioner.

High risk, high return, as they say.

Through qi accumulation, a Murim practitioner gained abilities that surpassed those of ordinary people. But if their heart meridian was severed, they also got a bonus one-plus-one event called qi deviation.

Just like now.

"Cough. Kueeegh!"

Splaash!

[2884] Here, a zhang is ten Korean ja, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Eyes, nose, mouth, ears. Dark-red blood and pale lumps that looked like internal organs poured endlessly from every opening I could see.

Namho and Taishan hurried over, only to stop short at the sight.

“Ugh. Taishan doesn’t want to look. Losing my appetite.”

“W-What is this?”

Namho swallowed hard and asked in a subdued voice, “Can they be saved?”

It was a pointless question. Things had already gone too far.

Before I could answer, the heads of two of the men, whose entire bodies had been twitching and convulsing, fell limply to the side.

Thud.

They were dead. No need to check.

But it was still too early to give up. I grabbed the last masked man’s wrist and poured my internal energy into him with all my strength.

Sssaaaaah.

As the heat of my Scorching Yang Qi flowed through him, I could feel the ruin inside his body.

Not one of his organs was undamaged. Even the qi pathways that should have been broad and sturdy in a Peak master had crumbled like the walls of an abandoned house.

And qi deviation on top of it…

Even Mungyeong, the greatest Divine Physician under Heaven, couldn’t have guaranteed this man would live. I knew he was beyond saving, and I clenched my teeth.

I have to find out. No matter what.

I needed just one name: the person who had ordered today’s attack.

I poured in more internal energy, not to bring the chaos inside him under control—that was impossible now—but to make his last ember flare.

Rumble!

His entire body struggled violently as an even greater flow of internal energy entered him.

Then, like water settling after a violent storm, the masked man at death’s door regained a brief moment of calm and clarity.

A final rally.

This was my last chance. I stared into his newly focused eyes.

“Who was it? Tell me.”

I pulled the mask away from his mouth to hear his answer—and realized that everything I’d just done was pointless.

“Cough. Hhh. Haaah.”

“…!”

“Grrk. Uhh…”

His jaw moved as though he were trying to speak, but no words came out.

No. He *couldn’t* speak.

I froze. Above me, Namho muttered something that sounded like a groan.

“Vicious bastards. Their tongues…”

He couldn’t finish, and the masked man had almost no time left.

“Grrk.”

A death rattle took the place of his last words. His pupils went vacant, and the shortened tongue that had been moving inside his open mouth fell still.

I stared silently at the man who had finally met his death, then spat out the curse I had been holding back.

“…Fuck.”

I’d known these men were no ordinary attackers. I hadn’t imagined their tongues had been cut.

That was why they hadn’t spoken a word from beginning to end, apart from their screams. Even if they’d wanted to, they couldn’t.

“Hmm. The others are the same. Judging by how the severed ends of their tongues have healed, it looks like this was done a long time ago.”

Namho quickly examined the corpses like the Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent he was, then let out a low groan.

“These men… They’re all Nanman.”

“No Han Chinese?”

“Not one. They’re dressed alike, so I can’t tell which tribes they came from, either.”

The most reliable way to distinguish the Nanman was by their clothing and eating habits. But since every one of them wore black clothes and a mask, it was only natural that they were difficult to identify.

Besides, there was only a subtle difference between the appearances of Han Chinese and Nanman. Trying to identify their tribe at a glance was practically absurd.

“…Damn it.”

As I muttered a curse mixed with a sigh, Namho fixed me with a deeply serious gaze.

“When you tried to persuade them, you named three Great Chieftains as possible culprits. Was it Heugung who sent the missive?”

I stared at him in surprise. That was answer enough.

“I see. So that’s what happened.”

“How did you know, Elder Namho?”

"Baeksang and Yohi were both people who could reasonably be named as culprits. But Heugung was different. Thinking about it, there could only be one reason you would have thought of him in this situation."

His tone was calm and sharp. "Was it him?"

"Yes." I nodded. "He was waiting for me at the place in the missive."

"He chose to hide in the forest instead of behind a rock. But even in a crowd, a man of Heugung's size would stand out. Did he come in person?"

"He had learned the Bone-Shrinking Technique. At first, I didn't even suspect that he was Heugung."

"Hah. The Bone-Shrinking Technique. He had more secrets than he let on. Fooled us all. Then again, if he were the man everyone thought he was, he'd never have sent you that missive."

Namho seemed to be speaking to himself. Then his expression grew heavy.

"Go on."

My account of Heugung was brief, but Namho listened to every word without interrupting. By the time I finished, the furrows between his brows had deepened.

"What a goddamn mess."

I agreed. An attack had taken place, and we were no closer to identifying who had ordered it.

Baeksang, Yohi, Heugung. I couldn't rule out any of them. And behind today's attack lay another name: Dark Heaven.

I can tell just from the fact that they severed their heart meridians instead of taking a poison pill.

A deadly poison would have been easy to find in Nanman. You could go on a picnic in the grass outside the Outer Palace and find venomous beasts crawling everywhere.

But the masked men had chosen to sever their own heart meridians. Compared with a quick death by poison pill, it meant suffering several times more pain.

I had no choice but to assume that they already knew about it.

The Myriad-Poison Ring. Dark Heaven must already know that I have it.

Dark Heaven had sent the Blood Lord to cause the Shaolin Bloodshed. In Sichuan, it had sent the Western Heaven Demon Lord to seize the divine artifacts of the Emei Sect and the Sichuan Tang Clan.

For those artifacts, it had committed Supreme Peak masters who could match the Ten Kings—perhaps even the Three Saints—along with elite troops.

But even immediately after the Sichuan Blood Tragedy ended, nothing happened to the Sichuan Tang Clan.

The Sichuan Tang Clan had staggered after suffering more severe damage than any other sect in Sichuan during its battle with the Western Heaven Demon Lord. But the follow-up attack from Dark Heaven that everyone had feared never came.

I suspected the Myriad-Poison Ring was the reason.

So they made sure these men severed their heart meridians instead of taking poison. They didn't want to leave even the slightest chance.

A drop of cold sweat ran down my spine.

My enemies were watching my every move, while I could not even identify the person hiding in the darkness.

The mere fact that an attack like this had taken place in the Inner Palace of the Nanman Beast Palace—the heart of Nanman—was threatening enough.

"When did the attack start?"

"I don't know exactly. I woke up in the middle of it, but… It seems to have started less than half a shichen[2885] after you left. I went to check because I wondered what was happening, and everything outside was in chaos. That bastard Sama Pyo was fighting while covered in blood."

He pointed to Sama Pyo, lying on the ground, and looked at me with concern.

"But is he all right? He seems to have lost a lot of blood fighting them."

"I've stopped the bleeding. He should be fine. I didn't find any wounds that looked immediately dangerous, and most of the blood on him seems to be theirs."

Taishan returned from dragging the corpses into a pile and blinked his enormous eyes.

"Pavilion Master, true? Taishan's Lord okay?"

"Yeah. He collapsed because he used too much strength."

Tears filmed Taishan's eyes.

"Sniff. Taishan was worried. If Lord died, Taishan wouldn't eat meat for three years. Sniff."

"…"

"…"

I'd heard of mourning for three years. Giving up meat for three years was new to me. Wouldn't that make him the strongest vegan in Murim?

I swallowed the words and patted his Ural-Mountains-sized shoulder.

"Yeah. You worked hard too."

"Sniff. Taishan used lots of strength. Taishan hungry."

"…Yeah. Okay."

Should I just punch him?

[2885] A shichen is a traditional period of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

But as I was deep in thought, countless footsteps began approaching from far away, accompanied by torchlight.

And with them came the familiar roar of a beast.

—Rooar!

Ssshhh! Pap!

A silver figure, unmistakable against the darkness, reached the clearing first.

Yayul Mok sat astride the White Tiger, his face as stiff as a wooden doll.

"…I'm late."

I answered evenly. "Yeah. Late enough that it's hard to believe this happened inside the Inner Palace."

A collapsed pavilion. Pools of blood scattered across the ground. A heap of corpses.

Yayul Mok bit his lip.

"The warriors on patrol were dead. We didn't find out until half a gak[2886] ago. And…"

What he said next made me wonder if I'd heard him right.

"Heugung and Yohi. Both Great Chieftains have disappeared."

…*What?*

[2886] A gak is a traditional period of about fifteen minutes; half a gak is about seven and a half minutes.

Chapter 655

Nanman was like a small country cut off from the Central Plains, with the Nanman Beast Palace as its royal palace.

Naturally, the Inner Palace was enormous. Nearly a thousand people lived there—warriors, cooks, servants, keepers who tended the beasts, and more. Whenever the Tribal Grand Council convened, that number swelled several times over.

Yet among all those people, four mattered more than the rest: the Great Chieftains.

They led the strongest four of Nanman's thirty-two tribes and had the power to become the next Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace. Their influence was immense, and for generations, the three Great Chieftains other than the Palace Lord had enjoyed special privileges.

Whoosh!

Yayul Mok, running beside me, was explaining one of them now.

"Every chieftain other than Father lives at their tribe's main base and must give advance notice before entering the Inner Palace. The Great Chieftains are exceptions. They're free to come and go, and each has a residence inside."

East, west, south, and north.

The north had traditionally belonged to the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace. The other Great Chieftains each had a residence in one of the remaining directions.

They were official residences granted to high-ranking figures. In Central Plains terms, it was as though the Son of Heaven had permitted his vassal princes to establish their own princely residences.

But after running there at full speed, what I found waiting for me was blood pooled across the ground, corpses, and the wreckage of a building someone had destroyed.

"What the…"

Namho's groan reached my ears. Feeling as though all the blood in my body had turned cold, I looked up.

A wooden plaque hung crookedly over the shattered gate. Three characters were written on it.

Western Yao Estate.

They told me whose estate this was. The image of a woman smiling with captivating eyes flashed through my mind.

Yohi. Great Chieftain of the Yao people.

"Bewitching" suited her better than "beautiful."

I didn't know whether she was behind tonight's attack, but two things were certain. This splendid estate, so thoroughly shaped by Yohi's tastes, was no longer as beautiful as it had been.

And Yohi herself had vanished without a trace.

Step.

I crossed through the half-destroyed gate. Bodies lay scattered everywhere, among them the carcasses of beasts. Flower beds that must once have bloomed in all different colors were soaked red with blood.

"…Fuck."

I couldn't keep the curse in. Just then, a warrior spotted Yayul Mok walking beside me and approached.

"Young Palace Lord. You've arrived."

Yayul Mok nodded, his face grim.

"You've worked hard. Have you found anything else?"

"No. Only more bodies."

Behind the warrior, corpses lay side by side. A few steps away, three or four warriors were hauling a tiger out of a well, its drenched body hanging limp.

"So far, we've confirmed at least a hundred dead, counting both Yao warriors and the beasts they commanded."

"Any survivors?"

The warrior was silent for a moment before answering.

"…None so far."

So far?

I doubted they'd find any. Keeping that thought to myself, I approached the bodies.

A warrior instinctively moved to block my way, but when our eyes met, he flinched and stepped aside. I examined the wounds, looking for how these people had fought the unknown attacker—and how they had died.

Then, just as I realized something, I heard Yayul Mok's voice.

"Found anything?"

Dozens of pairs of eyes turned toward me. I gave a brief answer.

"Force."

"…!"

"…!"

A ripple of unease passed through the crowd. My voice came out stiff.

"The attacker was undoubtedly a Supreme Peak master. Most of them probably didn't notice the attack until the last moment. The gap in martial arts was that great."

The Supreme Peak realm was open to only a chosen few. After enduring countless hardships and breaking through the barrier, its masters rose to a realm that made them, quite literally, superhuman.

With a single swing of a sword, they could kill dozens of First Rate masters. Even barehanded, they could beat a dozen Peak masters to a bloody pulp.

Whoever had attacked this place tonight was one of them.

Fast, economical, and utterly lethal.

I'd known as soon as I saw the wounds. The attacker was a seasoned killer.

They had slaughtered every living thing in the estate using no more force than necessary, and no less. Everyone in Murim knew that one chi[2887] of depth was enough to take a life. Only a Supreme Peak master could kill a hundred warriors and beasts that way.

The implication was clear.

—Are you saying Baeksang did all this?

Yayul Mok's quiet Sound Transmission reached my ear. I looked at his rigid face amid the shocked crowd.

—Who knows?

—What do you mean, who knows?

—Only two masters in Nanman have reached this level. One is Baeksang, as you know. The other… is someone everyone in Nanman knows well.

Yayul Mok went deathly pale. His mouth opened as though he were about to shout, but he bit down hard on his lip instead.

—Are you saying Father did this?

—Of course not.

—Then why…

—I'm saying that would be too obvious. What's certain is that Dark Heaven was directly involved.

Supreme Peak masters were exceedingly rare even in the Central Plains, and rarer still in Nanman. I might have my suspicions about Baeksang, but I wasn't that much of a blockhead.

Dark Heaven had probably sent one of its own Supreme Peak masters.

They seemed content to watch from a step away. Have they finally decided to act themselves?

But what were they after?

I kept the question to myself and spoke aloud rather than using Sound Transmission.

"There's something I want to check for myself. Shall we step away for a moment?"

Yayul Mok understood and gave the onlookers a glance. Their eyes turned away.

[2887] A chi is a traditional unit of length equal to about 3.03 cm (1.19 in).

The three of us—Yayul Mok, Namho, and I—entered the pavilion at the center of the estate. As we'd expected, the place that must once have been filled with rare furnishings looked as though a storm had torn through it.

"Looks like they put up a real fight," Namho muttered.

Yayul Mok answered, his face still grim. "But it was over in moments. With a Supreme Peak master against them, I suppose that was inevitable."

"How do you know how long it lasted?"

"Because I heard a short but unmistakable boom. By the time I heard the report and arrived, everything was already over. All that remained in the Western Yao Estate was blood, corpses, and…"

Rattle.

Yayul Mok slid open a large door. His voice sank.

"Those."

He meant two things lying in the wrecked room: a scent pouch, and something far more valuable in its use, though it gave off a terrible smell.

"Hmm."

Namho let out a low groan. I walked over without hesitation and touched the second object. It was cold, and sticky blood coated my fingers.

This is…

Anyone with eyes would recognize it.

A wrist. Someone's wrist, cleanly severed.

"Can you tell whose it is?"

How could I not?

I stared at the plump wrist for a moment before answering quietly.

"Probably Heugung's."

"That's right. He came to see Great Chieftain Yohi with four guards. The Eastern Yi Estate confirmed it."

If the Yao people had built the Western Yao Estate in the west, it seemed the Yi people under Heugung had established the Eastern Yi Estate in the east. I set Heugung's wrist down.

"When was that?"

"Less than half a shichen[2888] ago, but at least half an hour."

I worked out the timing. It was just after Heugung and I had parted. He must have gone straight to the Eastern Yi Estate, then come here to see Yohi.

…That lovesick bastard. He couldn't wait even that long.

I struggled to keep the curse from coming out. I needed to stay calm.

[2888] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

I still didn't know why Heugung had come to see Yohi. And until his death was confirmed, I had to suspect everyone.

"What happened to the guards he brought?"

"Dead. Along with the Yao warriors."

Of course. Fuck.

I'd asked just in case. I'd gotten exactly the answer I expected.

"Whew."

I let out a deep breath and slowly surveyed the room. Signs of resistance were everywhere. Beyond a wall that had probably collapsed under a powerful palm strike, I could see a rear garden that had kept its splendor.

There were faint footprints there, too.

They subdued the two of them quickly, then escaped through the rear garden.

The prints were too faint to tell me who had left them. But they did establish one thing: this wasn't an attack staged by Heugung or Yohi. A third party had been here.

Less than half an hour ago, at least three people had occupied this room.

And one of them was a Supreme Peak master.

So who had left those footprints? The Southern Heaven Demon Empress? Or one of the Dark Heaven masters under her command?

I thought it over, then shook my head.

I wasn't some old veteran of Murim. These clues could tell me only so much. Namho had encountered a wealth of information as an agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, but his knowledge concerned fiends' faces and other outward features.

In the end, I need someone with both a high level of martial arts and a high level of insight.

Only two names came to mind immediately, and one of them was someone I could never bring myself to trust.

I turned to Yayul Mok.

"When will Great Hero Yayul arrive?"

"I've already sent someone to notify him. By now, he should be on his way with the other chieftains."

That was good news. I made sure Heugung's wrist was where I'd found it, to preserve the scene, then sniffed the pouch Yohi had left behind. The silk had split along one side, and only the faintest trace of scent remained—almost nothing.

I'll find out what happened. No matter what.

Just then, a commotion broke out beyond the pavilion.

"Father must have arrived at last," Yayul Mok said. "He may be able to identify the attacker."

But before I even stepped outside, I knew he was wrong.

The Beast Miao King wasn’t the first to arrive. And the person being named as the culprit was someone I hadn’t expected.

“The guilty party is coming out on his own.”

The moment I heard Baeksang’s flat voice, I understood.

Baeksang and the Beast Miao King weren’t the only Supreme Peak masters in Nanman capable of doing this.

Chapter 656

Silence fell over the Western Yao Estate.

The warriors gathering the corpses stopped. So did the tribal chieftains who had clearly just arrived. Everyone stood motionless, looking this way.

No. They were looking at one person.

Me.

Then a cold voice broke the silence.

“The culprit walks out on his own two feet.”

The instant I met Baeksang’s deeply sunken eyes, a hollow laugh escaped me before I knew it.

“Ha.”

Realization struck in a flash. I didn’t need to think any further about where this was going. Baeksang’s greeting had told me everything.

The culprit.

For a moment, I’d forgotten that I fit every condition myself.

Instead of holding up a lantern to search the distance, I should have looked at the ground beneath my feet.

“Uncle Baek, what do you—”

Yayul Mok had been staring at Baeksang in confusion. Now he seemed to understand and fell silent. Namho, who might have caught on even faster than I had, sighed softly.

“Hah. I must be getting old. To fall for a trick this shallow.”

Namho was only half right.

The trap was shallow, but the pit beneath it would be deep enough that, once I stepped in, I wouldn’t easily climb out.

Damn it.

I felt as though I were sinking into a swamp. My chest tightened, and my mouth felt gritty, as if I’d been chewing sand.

I closed my eyes for a moment. When I opened them, the estate had become a courtroom, and everyone’s place in it was clear.

“Did you hear what Great Chieftain Baeksang said?”

“The culprit? Then could that Han Chinese man really be…?”

The warriors whispered among themselves. They were the spectators.

“I knew this would happen! Didn’t I say over and over that we should drive the Han Chinese out from the start?”

“Hmm. It’s still too early to jump to conclusions.”

“Too early? Even now you’re saying that? Jin Taekyung is the only one capable of doing something like this!”

Unlike the whispering warriors, the chieftains were raising their voices to condemn me. They were the jury.

And then there was Baeksang.

“You stand there so boldly. As if you’ve done nothing wrong.”

He had spoken before them all. He was the judge of this damn trial.

I looked at his impassive face. “Of course I can stand here boldly. I haven’t done anything wrong.”

There was no point worrying about courtesy anymore.

One of the chieftains bristled at my answer. “You bastard! How dare—”

“How dare I what?”

Ssshh!

The wave of qi I released shot toward him. The chieftain who had stepped forward went white as a sheet.

“Ghk.”

I was already at the top of a hundred-foot pole. One wrong step and I’d fall. If I let the momentum of this turn against me, it would be over.

I kept the powerful wave of qi flowing and spoke quietly.

“This isn’t a place where any dog or cow can butt in. Stay out of it.”

“…!”

Someone swallowed hard.

Then a deep voice carried on the wind.

“What a racket.”

Heads turned. A man everyone knew was walking through the gate of the Western Yao Estate.

The Beast Miao King.

His tiger-like eyes were wide, his frame as massive as a mountain ridge. He radiated a pressure like Mount Tai itself, and everyone hurried to one knee.

“We pay our respects to the Palace Lord!”

Their voices rang out as one.

The Beast Miao King advanced slowly, more chieftains following behind him. Then he spoke.

“Am I among the dogs and cattle you mentioned?”

There was no doubt who he meant. I shook my head.

“No.”

“Then I have a question for you.”

His low voice reached my ears.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. What connection do you have to the tragedy here today?”

He wasn’t asking because he suspected me. He was trying to help. I knew that better than anyone, and I answered without hesitation.

“None whatsoever.”

Whispers rose around us.

Baeksang, who had remained kneeling in silent respect, stood.

“Last year, a fire broke out in the western forest. It happened because of the carelessness of drunken Bai warriors, and as a result, more than two hundred livestock and more than thirty houses burned down.”

His voice remained dry.

“A crime demands punishment. I had to execute seven warriors of my own people with this hand. Yet when I asked for their last words, every one of them told me the same thing.”

His unreadable eyes stayed on me, but his words were for the Beast Miao King.

“I am innocent. I did not drink, and I did not start the fire.”

“…!”

“Two Great Chieftains have disappeared from the Inner Palace, and some hundred warriors have been slaughtered. A few flimsy words will not excuse anyone from this.”

The Beast Miao King closed his eyes. I stared at Baeksang.

“Listening to you, I get the strange feeling I’ve already been declared the culprit without knowing it.”

“If you’re truly innocent, prove it.”

“Prove it?”

“Yes. That’s the simplest way. Produce evidence that you aren’t the culprit, and the matter is settled.”

I didn’t get a chance to answer. No sooner had Baeksang finished speaking than he turned to the murmuring crowd and called out:

“I, Baeksang, Great Chieftain of the Bai people, will establish my own innocence before questioning the culprit. Heaven and earth shall bear witness, as will the fifteen chieftains and hundred warriors who were with me!”

“…!”

Damn it. Was this what he’d been after from the start?

I had fully expected Baeksang to have established a sufficient alibi, but the timing and flow with which he revealed it were too perfect.

As though they had been waiting for this very moment, the chieftains following Baeksang raised their voices more loudly than anyone.

“Palace Lord, Great Chieftain Baeksang speaks the truth. He was with us at the Southern Bai Estate from the moment the banquet ended.”

“The Jingpo Chieftain is correct! I, along with the Lahu people, swear it before Heaven!”

“The Wa people vouch for Great Chieftain Baeksang as well! When the tragedy occurred, we were meeting to prepare for tomorrow’s Tribal Grand Council!”

As their voices rose from all sides, Namho groaned behind me. The Beast Miao King’s expression grew grave.

Nearly half the chieftains had openly declared themselves part of a faction. But right now, not even the Beast Miao King could call them on it.

Two Great Chieftains had vanished from the Nanman Beast Palace, and close to a hundred lives had been brutally taken in the Inner Palace itself. Against a disaster like that, a factional struggle—even one that had become an open secret—was a mere ripple.

And then the moment came.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Now tell me: where were you at the time?”

A question I couldn’t avoid. An answer I couldn’t refuse to give.

Baeksang’s words and the eyes fixed on me felt like an invisible noose tightening around my whole body.

At the same time, someone touched my waist.

Tap.

I didn’t turn around. Namho had been standing behind me all along; I knew it was his hand.

Why?

He had a reason. I sharpened my senses and followed the movement of his finger.

It lasted only a moment, barely brushing my clothes, but I understood what he was trying to tell me.

He was writing two characters.

Silence.

Namho was telling me not to speak. Or perhaps to think again before I said what I was about to say.

The situation was taking an ominous turn.

What if I tell them I met Heugung?

Would they believe me? More likely, Baeksang and his chieftains would turn it against me.

Heugung had said he slipped out of his residence without anyone noticing, and he had even changed his appearance with the Bone-Shrinking Technique.

I can’t prove it.

If Heugung were here, perhaps I could. But unless the wrist he'd left behind could testify, my alibi was worthless.

On the other hand, saying I'd left my quarters for no reason would be digging my own grave. There had only ever been one answer I could give.

"My quarters."

Countless thoughts flashed through my mind, but little time passed. I answered without much delay, then took a deep breath and continued.

"I remained in my quarters immediately after the banquet ended. Then I was attacked."

"Attacked?"

Most of those present hadn't heard about it yet. As the crowd murmured, the Beast Miao King spoke, his face stern.

"Jin Taekyung is telling the truth. I received a report that assassins whose tribes could not be identified attacked them."

Yayul Mok had been shaken by the turn of events, but he made his voice steady.

"That's right. Some of the Inner Palace guards and I reached the scene about half an hour ago. We also confirmed that the warriors patrolling the area had been killed."

After the Beast Miao King, Yayul Mok also came to my aid, and the murmuring around us grew louder.

But I had been watching Baeksang all along, and I realized once again that something was wrong.

"I, too, heard there had been another tragedy in the Inner Palace."

His voice was cold, his eyes impassive. He turned to Yayul Mok.

"But those assassins entered the Inner Palace so easily, killed the warriors on patrol, and carried out their attack. They must have been formidable. Wouldn't you say?"

Before I could stop him, Yayul Mok answered.

"Yes. There were around thirty of them, and every one was as skilled as an elite warrior—"

He never finished. He couldn't.

Because Baeksang's voice pierced everyone's ears in the next moment.

"Strong enough to kill a Supreme Peak master who inherited the Fire King's legacy?"

"…!"

"…!"

"And if this clumsy assassination attempt was meant to keep Jin Taekyung occupied, that makes no sense either. He would have stayed in his quarters if

they'd left him alone. Why attack him and draw attention? The more you think about it, the stranger it becomes."

The air shifted. Dozens of wide eyes turned on me, their stares prickling against my face.

Yet I felt calmer.

Not because I thought I could get out of this. I had already half accepted what was happening.

This trap was large and deep—far beyond anything I had imagined.

When did it start? How much of this was planned?

I stared at Baeksang, still searching for answers, and spoke.

"I don't think this is the end."

He nodded at once.

"Good instincts."

"Something else to say?"

"No. Something to show you."

Snap.

With his dry answer, Baeksang snapped his fingers. From the half-destroyed gate of the Western Yao Estate, a faint presence began to draw closer.

Step. Step.

Short, uneven strides. Slow footsteps.

Like someone who was ill. Or…

An old man.

I recognized that oddly familiar presence and closed my eyes. When an elderly voice reached me, I opened them again.

"U-Utu-ri of the Bai people. I came at the Great Chieftain's summons."

The old owner of the noodle shop stood before the gate.

Chapter 657

Something big is coming.

My gut was right. The old owner of the thin-noodle shop where I'd sat with Heugung not long ago had appeared.

Fuck.

Something big really had come.

I stared at the old shopkeeper, cursing inwardly.

I wasn't the only one. As countless eyes turned toward him, a trembling voice came from between his age-spotted lips.

"U-Utu-ri of the Bai people. I came at the Great Chieftain's summons."

The Beast Miao King spoke, his face grim.

"I've never seen him before. Who is he?"

At a glance from Baeksang, the old shopkeeper answered at once.

"I sell thin noodles near the West Gate of the Outer Palace. I've made my living doing that for more than half my life."

His words and actions taught me several new things.

First. The old shopkeeper's name was Utu-ri, and he was one of the Bai people.

Second. Unlike at the noodle shop, Utu-ri could speak clearly and hear perfectly well. In short, he was full of life. Jirisan had its baby hero Utu-ri; Nanman had its noodle-selling Utu-ri.[2889]

Third. This Bai elder, spry enough to put his age to shame, had probably told Baeksang everything he'd seen and heard.

And fourth. I was probably fucked.

You have to understand. The owner here is over ninety, so his hearing is bad.

Heugung, you son of a bitch.

What he'd said at the noodle shop could hardly have been more wrong.

Bad hearing, my ass.

The only thing looking dim was my future.

The shopkeeper, supposedly over ninety, had heard the Beast Miao King from ten paces away.

"Utu-ri, I called you here to confirm one thing. Do you recognize anyone present?"

"Yes."

The old shopkeeper nodded without hesitation, and I realized I had another item to add.

Fifth. Besides excellent hearing, Utu-ri had remarkable eyesight and memory.

[2889] The baby general Utu-ri is a child hero associated with Jirisan in Korean folklore.

That much was easy to tell. From the moment he'd entered the Western Yao Estate, he'd kept stealing glances at my face.

"That young man standing over there. The tallest one, with the broad build."

The hand that had trembled like an aspen tree when he set down the bowls of noodles was, for some reason, perfectly still this time.

Damn it.

His finger pointed directly at me. I shut my mouth, the atmosphere around us began to stir, and the script Baeksang had meticulously prepared raced toward its conclusion.

"Are you certain it was him? You must not tell even the slightest lie."

The old shopkeeper swallowed hard before answering.

"Yes, without a doubt. I may be old and worn-out, but I'm not so blind that I can't recognize a customer standing right in front of me. His build was exceptionally large, and he was wearing a tiger mask, so he stood out in my memory."

"Half the people in the Outer Palace must be wearing masks right now. Did you report him as suspicious for that reason alone?"

"N-No, sir. He lingered nearby before sitting down and ordering noodles. That was when I started to find him suspicious."

"Suspicious? What exactly troubled you?"

"Well, the thing is…"

The old shopkeeper glanced at me, then continued cautiously.

"It was the mask, sir."

"The mask?"

"Yes. He kept it on even while he ate. As though something terrible would happen if anyone saw his face."

"I see. Continue."

"But later, when he drank the broth, the mask must have felt too restrictive, because he raised it slightly. That was the first and only time I saw his face."

So that was when.

If I showed my whole face, they might realize I was Han Chinese. But keeping the mask on would look suspicious too. I'd deliberately raised it only as far as the bottom of my nose while I ate, then lifted it for a moment at the very end…

And the old man who looked ready to die any day saw it and remembered.

At first, my excessive caution had drawn suspicion. Later, overlooking the existence of the old shopkeeper had brought me to this situation.

Baeksang, in his usual even tone, was bringing the matter to a close.

"Was he alone?"

"No. He shared a table with a middle-aged man."

"Another middle-aged man. And afterward?"

“They left at almost the same time, then headed toward the main road by the West Gate.”

“Do you remember the other man’s face?”

“Yes, of course. I’ve lived in the Outer Palace all my life, but I’d never seen him around before, so I remember him clearly. The same goes for that young man.”

“Then they were certainly outsiders who entered during the Tribal Grand Council. If we make likenesses of them and investigate, it should be easy to identify them. When did they leave?”

“Around Insi.[2890] They stayed about as long as it takes to drink a cup of tea. The Outer Palace has been setting off firecrackers at regular intervals, so I remember the time clearly.”

The old shopkeeper answered without faltering. His eyes and voice were full of conviction.

Baeksang had gotten every answer he wanted. He gave a small nod.

“Thank you for your cooperation. You may go. I’ll have someone reward you.”

“Th-Thank you. Thank you, Great Chieftain!”

The old shopkeeper bowed repeatedly as he left.

He’d probably be rewarded handsomely for this. The little stall that filled up with three or four customers would become a large inn, and the wrinkled hands that boiled noodles would count silver nyang[2891] instead.

But the opportunity he’d found in his old age had become the worst crisis of my life.

“How strange. A man who ought to have been in the Inner Palace slipped out in secret, met with someone whose identity is unknown, and immediately afterward, this tragedy occurred.”

“…”

“Your earlier statement has already been exposed as a lie. Still, in light of what happened at Ailao Mountain, I’ll give you one last chance. Do you have anything to say in your defense?”

Countless thoughts flashed through my mind in the brief moment Baeksang’s low voice reached me.

The Western Yao Estate had fallen into suffocating silence. Everyone was looking at me.

Then Namho’s finger brushed my back again.

Sssrk.

Escape.

One character. It was enough to tell me what he meant.

[2890] Insi is a traditional time period from 3 to 5 a.m.

[2891] A silver nyang was a historical Korean unit of silver currency.

Get out of here first. Worry about what comes next later.

If Namho had learned martial arts, that was the Sound Transmission he would have sent me. I'd probably have done the same in his place.

Would it have gone better if I'd told the truth?

I answered my own question. No.

Maybe it would have gone a little better than this. But Baeksang had prepared thoroughly. One way or another, he would have backed me into the same corner.

I could claim the old noodle seller was lying, but… come on. If Baeksang were stupid enough to fall for that, he wouldn't have made it this far.

Besides, a master like Baeksang would realize just by looking at the wounds on the assassins who attacked us that most of them weren't my handiwork.

Without Heugung there to corroborate my statement, telling the truth would only make me a shameless culprit.

Though I suppose that would beat being a culprit caught in a lie.

Either way, I was trapped. There was no getting around it.

And even now, things were hurtling toward the edge.

Sssrk.

A faint sound reached me through the brief silence. Leather shoes crushed blood-soaked grains of sand, while dozens of fluttering hems brushed the flowers in the garden.

In an instant, they had formed a ring around me.

Baeksang stood at its head.

"I'll ask again. Your defense?"

My defense.

After careful consideration, I answered.

"I'm not giving you one. This whole thing's filthy, you fucking bastard."

"…!"

"…!"

Apparently, that wasn't the answer they'd expected. Baeksang studied me with a look of surprise, then nodded.

"Are you admitting your guilt?"

"I admit I lied. That was stupid of me."

"So you intend to deny the rest to the end."

"Would you admit it in my place? There's nothing to admit when I haven't committed a crime. I'm just pissed that I walked into a trap I couldn't avoid."

"If you've been wronged, surrender peacefully. I'll sort out right from wrong."

"Yeah, fucking right. Right and wrong, my ass, you prick."

At my scornful answer, Baeksang's eyes darkened.

“Then I have no choice.”

At the same time—

Shing. Tsststst!

A dazzling radiance surged from the pure-white blade he drew in a flash. Baeksang lowered his treasured sword, infused with Sword Force, and slowly stepped forward.

“Warriors of the Nanman Beast Palace, listen. We will use our full strength to seize the criminal Jin Taekyung. Not a single mistake will be tolerated—”

At that moment, a roar-like shout erupted from somewhere, drowning out the words that were about to leave Baeksang’s mouth.

“Baeksang!”

Only one person in all Nanman could address the Great Chieftain of the Bai people that way.

“All of you, stop!”

Whoosh!

A powerful wave of qi pressed down on us from every direction.

The Beast Miao King had halted the tightening ring with a single command. His eyes blazed as he glared at Baeksang.

“What do you think you’re doing?”

Everyone trembled beneath his fierce aura. Baeksang did not.

“Exactly what you see, Palace Lord. I intend to seize the criminal Jin Taekyung here.”

“Have you forgotten? He is a pavilion master of the Murim Alliance and a member of the Fire Gate Clan, our longtime ally.”

“Are you, the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, shielding a culprit for those reasons alone?”

“Nonsense! He is not the culprit. Have you already forgotten what happened at Ailao Mountain? He has no cause or reason to do such a thing!”

“But we have a witness who saw him, and clear evidence pointing to him.”

“That’s—”

“Everyone here remembers what happened at Ailao Mountain, myself included. That is why I’m taking the trouble to capture him. Of course, if he resists, we’ll take him dead or alive.”

“Baeksang!”

“I’m not finished.”

Baeksang’s cold voice continued.

“If Jin Taekyung forces his way out of here, I’ll cast a net over heaven and earth across all Nanman and hunt him down with everything we have. Before that, the other Han Chinese under his command will make fine examples.”

"…!"

The Beast Miao King's eyes widened. Baeksang was saying he would risk war with the Central Plains. Yayul Mok shouted, his face contorted.

"Uncle!"

"This is a conversation between tribal chieftains, not between lord and subject. The Young Palace Lord has no authority here. Stay out of it."

"But how could you! How could you dare make such a unilateral decision on your own!"

"On my own…"

Baeksang muttered the words softly, then suddenly raised his head and looked at the sky.

The thick darkness around us had begun to lift. Light was slowly spreading from the east.

"Do you see? It's already the hour of the Rabbit.[2892] Dawn is breaking."

"What does that have to do with anything?"

"What if we begin the second day of the Tribal Grand Council right here? With a new matter on the agenda, of course…"

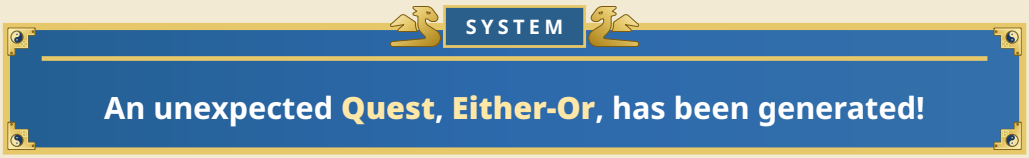
Tsst.

The sword in Baeksang's hand shone more fiercely.

"Whether the Han Chinese Jin Taekyung lives or dies."

At that moment, a bell sounded in my ears—a bell only one person in the world could hear.

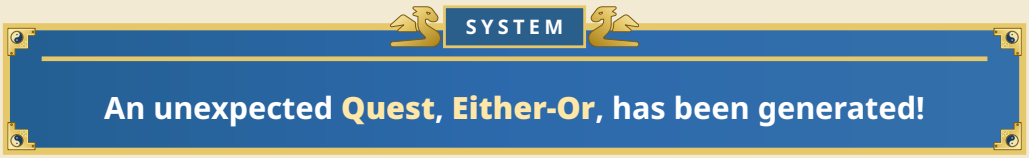
Ding.



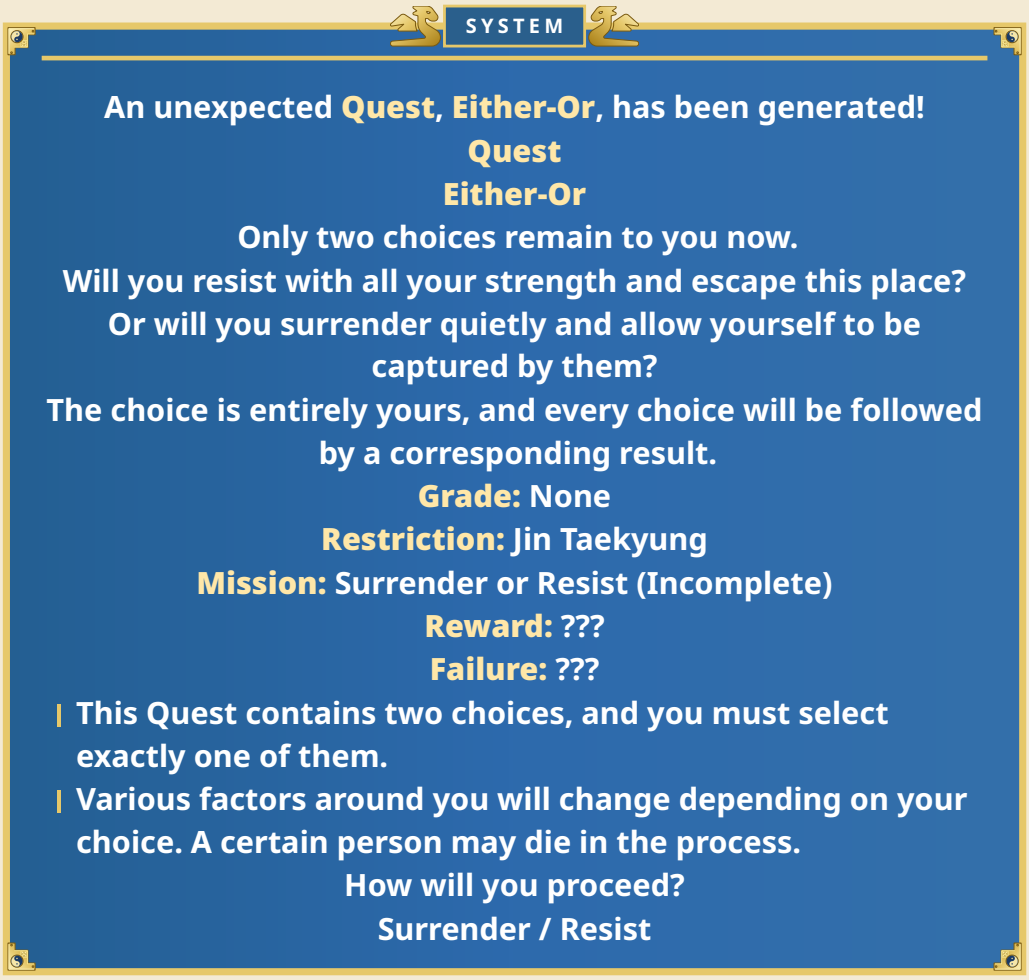
[2892] The hour of the Rabbit is a traditional time period from 5 to 7 a.m.

Chapter 658

Ding.



A System notification rang out. At the same time, a translucent holographic window sprang up in midair.



I had only one thought after reading the System window.

What a shitty situation.

Either-Or.

The sudden Quest was exactly what its title said.

Surrender or resist.

There were only two choices, and I had to make one. The situation—and the voices rising all around me—demanded it.

“I agree with Great Chieftain Baeksang.”

"Exactly! If the Palace Lord thinks this is an arbitrary decision, then let us convene the Tribal Grand Council right here and now!"

"If he is innocent, he should surrender quietly and submit to an investigation. What is the problem?"

A hollow laugh escaped me as I listened to the pro-Baeksang chieftains.

What's the problem?

The biggest problem was that this was Murim, not the modern world.

Judicial corruption happened even in the twenty-first century. I didn't need to see what would happen to me once Baeksang had me locked up.

They'll brand me a criminal from the start and make sure I stay one.

There would be no fairness in the process. My ill-considered lie had already been exposed, and Baeksang had produced a witness and clear circumstantial evidence.

It was a carefully dug trap. Once I'd stepped into it, there was nowhere to go but down.

Still, some people spoke up for me.

"You're all insane. Have you lost your minds? You intend to kill Jin Taekyung? Are you planning to start a war with all of Murim in the Central Plains?"

"We don't even know for certain that he's the culprit. Why would a pavilion master of the Murim Alliance and the Fire King's disciple do such a thing?"

"He rescued no fewer than two hundred warriors from Ailao Mountain. And you claim he is the culprit? Even if you hate the Han Chinese, how can you act like ungrateful beasts?"

This time, it was the chieftains who followed the Beast Miao King shouting.

But of the dozen or so, only a few stepped forward. Many others watched in confusion or kept their mouths firmly shut.

Of course. I'm an outsider in the end.

The Nanman people had never felt particularly well disposed toward the Han Chinese. My actions at Ailao Mountain were the only reason a Han Chinese man like me had been granted the extraordinary privilege of attending the Tribal Grand Council. That was as far as they were willing to go.

I didn't blame them. They could see which way things were turning.

Even if the Tribal Grand Council convened here and now, as Baeksang had suggested, it couldn't turn this around.

Not even for the Beast Miao King.

I think I'm pretty fucked.

The Beast Miao King's brow furrowed as my Sound Transmission reached him.

…You crazy bastard.

Why?

You can still joke at a time like this?

I'm telling you the truth. I can't sit here bawling like a child. It wouldn't make anything better.

At my Sound Transmission, which calmly faced reality, the Beast Miao King bit down hard on his lip.

I'm sorry. If the Tribal Grand Council is held as Baeksang says… there will be nothing I can do.

Still, it's a relief that Great Hero Yayul seems to believe me.

Of course I believe you. That's why I'm all the more sorry.

Then instead of apologizing, could you punch each of those bastards in the mouth? If that's too awkward, I'll do it.

…

Or use Flame Divine Palm.

Hah. At this point, you may as well be Old Master Jeok's flesh and blood rather than his Disciple.

Jeok Cheongang.

At the three syllables of his name, a familiar face suddenly flashed before my eyes, and my mouth turned bitter. If Jeok Cheongang were in this situation, how would he have handled it?

No. If it were Old Master Jeok, things never would have reached this point.

I wasn't nearly as strong as Jeok Cheongang. Despite thinking I'd grown used to Murim, I was still woefully inexperienced. And my enemies were more thorough and cunning than I'd imagined.

If this were Go… my actions would probably count as a bad move.

I didn't know how to play Go. But when I was little, my father sometimes sat at the computer and played online.

His username was Jin Sedol, though his win rate was terrible. Whenever he lost to a user from China, he'd mutter, "That Chink bastard plays Go like shit… Taiwan number one," and Mom would smack him on the back for swearing in front of me.

That was all ancient history.

A few years later, my father died suddenly in a Monster Wave. His Go account, steadily used through defeat after defeat, fell dormant.

But why was it that, all of a sudden, I remembered that day when I had watched my father losing at Go?

"Dad, are you losing again?"

"What do you mean, *again*? Dad's only losing this game. No, it's not even over yet."

"But you lost yesterday and the day before. And I saw you losing earlier!"

"…My sweet boy. You've grown so big you can drive a nail straight through your father's heart."

But why do you always lose, Dad?

"Hmm. I made a bad move."

"A handshake?"[2893]

"Not that kind of move. I mean a bad play. Like yesterday at the sports festival, when you kicked Minjun's leg instead of the soccer ball by mistake and lost the game. A bad choice. Understand?"

"Uh-huh! So if you make a bad move, you lose at Go?"

"Not necessarily."

Why?

"One bad move doesn't end the game. You lose when you keep making them. Hmm. I shouldn't have done that."

"But I got sent off right away yesterday."

"Son, wasn't that because you fractured Minjun's leg?"

"Ohh."

"What do you mean, 'ohh'? I nearly broke my back apologizing to Minjun's parents. Anyway, what matters is not making bad moves over and over."

"What happens if you do?"

"In Go, you lose your precious stones and eventually lose the game. That's the price of bad choices."

"I know! That's why you always lose, Dad!"

"…Honey! Take Taekyung away! Honey!"

I didn't know why that memory had come back to me now.

No. Maybe I did.

It had helped me make up my mind.

Can you promise me one thing?

Why have you gone quiet all of a sudden… A promise?

Yes. A promise.

I looked straight at the Beast Miao King and sent another Sound Transmission.

No matter what happens from this point on, promise me you'll make sure the others can return safely to the Central Plains.

…!

That's all I need.

You… Surely you aren't…

I'll take that as a promise.

The Beast Miao King stared at me, eyes wide, as though he'd guessed what I intended. Then he nodded, his face troubled.

I promise. I'll use every bit of power I have to protect your subordinates. I'll clear your name, too.

[2893] In Korean, *aksu* means both a bad move in Go (□□) and a handshake (□□).

Good. That's enough.

I muttered inwardly and began walking toward Baeksang.

Or I would have, if two hands hadn't reached from behind and seized my clothes.

Grab!

"Jin Taekyung. What are you planning to do?"

Yayul Mok's face was rigid. Namho, who had already figured it out, spoke next.

"You foolish bastard. Are you planning to walk into a tiger's mouth on your own?"

"I'm not sure whether it's a tiger's jaws or a fucking mutt's."

I shrugged.

"But things have come to this. What else can I do?"

Namho's gaze grew darker than I'd ever seen it.

"Is it because of me and the others? You're afraid we'll be hurt if you escape?"

"Hmm. I don't know."

"If that's what you're thinking, forget it. None of us would want—"

"I know. I know how you all feel."

I cut him off gently.

"But it would be the same if our positions were reversed. If the other members were in my place, or if Elder Namho were me right now, you wouldn't run away alone either."

…!

"See you later."

His eyes wavered, but he said nothing. I pulled my clothes free, gave them both a look in farewell, and walked on.

Step. Step.

Silence had settled all around us. My footsteps seemed to thunder as I crossed the space alone, while Baeksang watched me, as still as an undisturbed lake.

"Have you finally come to your senses?"

"Someone told me a long time ago that if you make too many bad moves in Go, you lose your precious stones and the game."

If this were an actual game of Go, I'd play however I liked. To hell with bad moves.

So what if I lost? A famous professional player had once said that, in the end, it was only Go. And to me, it really would be only Go.

After losing, I could simply smash Baeksang's head open with the Go board while saying, just like my father had, "That Chink bastard plays Go like shit."

But this wasn't a game. Here, a bad move would cost me my people instead of stones.

Ju Hwaran. Hyuk Mujin. Song Ilseom. Sama Pyo. Taishan. Namho…

Even if I got out of here, breaking through the Nanman Beast Palace's net over heaven and earth with all of them would be nearly impossible.

They'd trusted me and followed me this far. I had to keep them alive.

Whatever it took.

"If you keep making bad moves, you lose your precious stones and eventually the game… Whoever told you that was wise."

"He was a good man. At least he wasn't a piece of shit like you."

Shing! Shing! Shing!

Weapons came free on every side, as though everyone had agreed on a signal. Baeksang glanced at the tightening ring and waved his sleeve.

"For once, I commend you for avoiding a bad move. Even the Fire King's disciple had no other choice."

"I'm not doing this for praise from a piece of shit like you."

"No matter. You're going straight to the underground prison."

"An underground prison. Can't say I'm glad to hear that."

"We'll have iron balls weighing several thousand geun[2894] ready for you as well. You may look forward to them."

"Sure. My balls are trembling with anticipation already."

It was more or less what I'd expected. I answered calmly, then addressed Baeksang as he slowly sheathed his sword.

"But why aren't you looking forward to it?"

"What?"

"Didn't you say earlier that if I ran, you'd kill all my people?"

"Why bring that up now—"

I had no reason to hear the rest of his words. Nor did I need to.

Say that kind of bullshit to me, and you should expect a punch.

Along with a final word he could not hear, I thrust out a single fist like a ray of light.

Crack!

Without waiting to see the result, I shouted as fast as I could.

"Ah, I surrender! I surrenderrr!"

What are you going to do about it, fucker?

[2894] A *geun* is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g, or about 1.32 lb.

Chapter 659

Crack.

A large, fur-covered paw crushed a brittle leaf.

Fangs showed between parted jaws. The sleek body crouched deep in the grass was ready to hunt.

What kind of meat will I eat today?

All it had to do was spot its prey, sprint in, and sink its fangs into the back of its neck.

As long as it watched out for venomous beasts that appeared without warning, finding prey in Nanman was easy enough.

At least, it was for a black leopard near the top of the food chain.

Grrrr…

The leopard scanned its surroundings with bright yellow eyes, then let out a low growl.

It had sensed a great many presences in the distance and caught their scent on the wind.

Sniff, sniff.

Its senses were sharp, as a predator’s should be. It did not take long to identify the prey it had encountered sooner than expected.

Humans.

More precisely, a group of humans. Roughly a hundred of them were approaching.

Grrr.

The leopard gave an involuntary growl of irritation.

Humans were unwelcome. Small as they were, they sometimes hunted predators much larger than themselves. And the more of them there were, the stronger they became.

Just like now.

Swish.

The leopard rose from its crouch.

Hunting humans alone was for fools. It would be smarter to move elsewhere and find different prey.

It was about to do just that when—

“Whew. Whew…”

The leopard stopped and stared beyond the grass.

A human came running up, making strange noises, and squatted among the weeds.

“Ahh. I almost died.”

At the same time, sounds and smells that would have made even predators recoil filled the air. A glint flashed through the black leopard's vertically slit pupils.

There was no doubt about it. This human had left the group to relieve himself.

He had no idea this place would be his grave.

Grrr.

One target. A stupid-looking human at that.

The leopard made its decision in an instant. The muscles in all four legs tightened, and its black body shot forward like an arrow.

Tap—whoosh!

Several dozen feet vanished in an instant. Only then did the human notice something and turn his head toward the leopard.

A beat too late. Fangs flashed inside the leopard's wide-open jaws.

—Raaaar!

Thud! Crunch!

The sound of flesh being torn rang out beneath the beast's thunderous roar. Large and small bodies tangled together and rolled across the ground.

A moment later, the survivor of that short, fierce struggle made himself heard.

"Phew!"

The man who emerged from the black fur had blood all over his face.

The leopard's blood.

At the last moment, he had driven his sword into the head of the predator that ruled this stretch of forest. Now he panted for breath.

"Huff. Hah. Fuck. I nearly died taking a dump."

An ambush while he was doing his business. Thinking back, it had been far too close.

A year or two ago, he would have ended up as the leopard's dinner.

But like a seed putting out shoots, he had grown considerably since then.

"Getting beaten all the time really has improved my reflexes… But how do I get out from under this thing?"

The man—Hyuk Mujin—was still trapped beneath the impossibly heavy carcass of the black leopard, struggling and grunting, when—

"Strange. Was this the business you said you had to take care of?"

A familiar voice reached his ears, and his face lit up.

"Oh! Great Hero Song!"

Song Ilseom sighed.

"I told you not to call me Great Hero."

"Why not? You're helping someone in trouble. Doesn't that make you a Great Hero?"

"You take after your superior. The words flow right out of you."

"I'll take that as a compliment. But don't say it in front of Captain. Even you might find yourself getting beaten as freely as the words flow."

Song Ilseom nodded at Hyuk Mujin's heartfelt warning.

"…I'll bear that in mind."

"Good thinking. Now, could you get this thing off me? I can barely breathe. I keep seeing my father's face."

"Really? When did he die?"

"What are you talking about? He's alive and well."

"…?"

Is he insane?

Song Ilseom gave the question a moment's serious thought, then abandoned it and grabbed the leopard's carcass.

Few people in the Fire Dragon Pavilion he had somehow joined were sane. The Pavilion Master was the worst of them.

Scrape. Thud.

Freed at last from the danger of being crushed to death, Hyuk Mujin brushed the dirt from his clothes.

"Whew. That was close. Where is everyone?"

"Setting up camp. The Young Bureau Head stayed there too. We've been riding nearly ten shichen[2895] without a break, so she seems to have decided we need to rest. A missive arrived while you were away."

"A missive?"

"Yes. It seems the Nanman Beast Palace sent a messenger eagle. They must have further instructions."

"Either way, that's good news. The beasts have been moving so violently that I nearly shattered my rear end."

"They need rest too. Still, the Nanman people must train them well. They have impressive stamina—every bit as much as grassland horses."

About a day earlier, they had left the Outer Palace with the reconnaissance squad and pressed on without respite.

They had no idea when the Blood Monk, an old monster none of them had ever heard of before, might cross Guangxi and head south. A forced march was the obvious choice.

"When are we supposed to arrive?"

"According to the two tribal chieftains, in two days if we're quick. Three at the latest. The Young Bureau Head seems to think the same."

"Why do I get the feeling that means we have to make it in two?"

[2895] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; ten shichen is about twenty hours.

“Because we do. We need to move as quickly as possible to stop the Blood Monk.”

“As quickly as we’ve been moving?”

“Possibly faster.”

“…Faster might be a bit much.”

Hyuk Mujin grimaced, then nodded.

“Damn it. Not much choice, I guess.”

“You accepted that sooner than I expected.”

“Try following Captain around for a couple of years, Great Hero Song. You’ll learn to give up on anything. Your life included.”

“Unfortunately, that won’t happen.”

“Why not?”

“If not for the Young Bureau Head, I would never have come this far. She is the one and only reason I’m in this wretched Nanman.”

Hyuk Mujin shrugged at the curt reply.

“Hmm. Then I guess we’ll be seeing a lot of you.”

“What?”

“You just said it yourself. You came this far because of Young Lady Ju. And Young Lady Ju is going to stay with Captain, isn’t she?”

“…!”

“Great Hero Song, you’re not as bright as I thought.”

Song Ilseom went still for a moment. Then he asked evenly, “Do you want to die?”

“No. Sorry.”

Hyuk Mujin answered at once. Keeping a wary eye on Song Ilseom, he pulled his sword from the leopard’s head.

Spurt.

Blood gushed from the gaping wound. Hyuk Mujin gave the blade a cursory wipe and sheathed it, then looked up at the sky.

“It’s night already.”

They had apparently set out at night, but while moving without a moment to think, the second night had already arrived.

And several more nights would pass before they returned to the Nanman Beast Palace.

“I’d rather not run into the Blood Monk, though. It’s hard not to worry with Captain gone. You feel the same way, don’t you, Great Hero Song?”

No answer came.

After a brief silence, what he heard behind him was not Song Ilseom’s voice, but the cold scrape of a blade leaving its sheath.

Shing.

Hyuk Mujin recognized the sound coming from behind him and swallowed dryly.

"Uh, about calling you dumb. I'm sorry. Are you really angry?"

Song Ilseom's voice came back cold.

"…Shut up and turn around."

"Great Hero Song. Please. I'm begging you."

"I'm begging you. Shut up and turn around. Draw your sword again."

He's really lost it.

Tears in his eyes, Hyuk Mujin turned on trembling legs.

And then he understood why Song Ilseom's voice had gone cold. Why he had told him to draw his sword.

"I thought they were on our side… Was I wrong?"

Rustle.

The dark grass shifted.

The reconnaissance squad—the hundred or so people who had traveled with them until now—stood beyond it. At their head, the two tribal chieftains emerged and regarded them with troubled expressions.

"You weren't the only one who thought so. I regret that it's come to this."

"We received a missive bearing the Palace's seal. It's an order we cannot refuse."

A missive.

At those two words, Song Ilseom had a vague sense that something serious had happened in the Inner Palace they had left behind.

But right now, only one person mattered.

"Where is the Young Bureau Head?"

Killing intent seeped into the question.

Chief Jang, a supporter of the Palace Lord who had favored Jin Taekyung since the Tribal Grand Council, sighed.

"Her sword was fiercer than I expected. She caught on quickly, too."

"I'll ask one last time. Where is she?"

Whoosh!

Killing intent poured from Song Ilseom, so savage that even the beasts with the reconnaissance squad backed away.

Sensing his fury, the other tribal chieftain hurried to answer.

"Sh-she's safe. We only subdued her with a Pressure-Point Strike."

Song Ilseom clenched his teeth without realizing it. Relief and regret surged through him together.

I should have stayed by her side, no matter what.

Given the size of the reconnaissance squad that had turned against them, staying probably would not have changed the outcome.

But he could not stop picturing Ju Hwaran fighting alone.

"…Damn it."

As he spat out the curse, Song Ilseom slowly lowered the cherished weapon in his hand.

Hyuk Mujin, a little slower to grasp the situation, did the same.

Scrape. Thunk.

His carefully forged blade sank into the ground.

Chief Jang watched with a troubled look, then gestured. Warriors from the reconnaissance squad hurried forward, took their weapons, and bound them.

"…Great Hero Song. I think we're fucked."

Song Ilseom did not answer Hyuk Mujin this time either.

He couldn't.

Tap, tap, tap.

Someone's fingers tapped all over his body. As he felt his body stiffen under the Pressure-Point Strike, Song Ilseom muttered inwardly,

What the hell have you done, Jin Taekyung?

Chapter 660

"We've subdued them all. We struck their Sleep Acupoints too, so they won't regain consciousness for at least a day."

"…Good work."

Chief Jang nodded at his warrior's report, his expression troubled. Song Ilseom and Hyuk Mujin lay motionless, and their figures were reflected in his eyes.

"We don't know what might happen. Keep a close watch on them. We'll rest for two shichen[2896] and then move out."

"Does that mean…?"

"Yes. They're coming with us."

"Chief… Forgive me for speaking out of turn, but wouldn't it be better to send a few warriors to escort the prisoners to the Inner Palace separately?"

The warrior regretted asking as soon as the words were out. Chief Jang only stared at him.

"I'll carry out your orders."

He hurried away. Watching him go, Chief Jang sighed as the contents of the letter delivered by messenger eagle came back to him.

Heugung and Yohi, two Great Chieftains, have gone missing. The Western Yao Estate has been wiped out. And they're blaming Jin Taekyung?

He had read it several times, unable to believe his eyes. But the words in the missive had not changed, and he had only one choice.

I'm sorry, all of you.

The apology would never reach them. Soon, though, they would understand that this was the best he could do under the circumstances.

This was a carefully planned plot. Jin Taekyung was caught up in it unexpectedly.

Chief Jang did not believe the missive's accusation.

Everything he had seen of Jin Taekyung fit what the Han Chinese of the Central Plains called a Great Hero. If Jin had not risked his life fighting in the Poisonblood Grounds, more than two hundred warriors would never have returned to their families. Among those who had come home were warriors of Chief Jang's own Zang people, including his blood relatives.

And even setting aside what I owe him, there isn't a sound reason for him to have done it.

Nanman and the Central Plains had fallen out after the Great Faction War, but that was largely one-sided hostility born of the tremendous sacrifices Nanman had suffered. Why would Jin Taekyung, sent here as a representative of the Murim Alliance, cause such a tragedy?

[2896] A *shichen* is a traditional unit of time equal to about two hours.

Unless he wants to make an enemy of Nanman as well as Dark Heaven…

But Chief Jang could do nothing about the accusation now. Baeksang and his faction had already seized control of the situation.

However, the Palace Lord, the Beast Miao King, had secretly conveyed his intentions through a messenger eagle.

> Detain the Han Chinese in the reconnaissance squad, but do not escort them to the Inner Palace.

Chief Jang understood exactly what the Beast Miao King meant.

If we take them to the Inner Palace, they'll surely end up as hostages.

Fortunately, Chief Go, who was leading the reconnaissance squad alongside him, also followed the Beast Miao King. Since the two men shared the same opinion, they had their warriors subdue the three of them—not to make hostages of them, but to keep them in their own hands and protect them.

The timing helped. They were already on the move to watch for an old monster known as the Blood Monk. With a threat like that looming, Baeksang's faction could hardly use their decision to keep the prisoners with the squad against them.

Just bear with it a little longer. At least until this is settled.

Chief Jang stepped toward the two unconscious men being carried away. He felt bad for them and meant to loosen their bindings a little.

"Stop a moment. Aren't those ropes tied too tightly?"

"Chief! Don't!"

"What do you mean, don't? It'll be fine—"

Squelch.

Ignoring the warriors, Chief Jang reached behind Hyuk Mujin's back and frowned.

What is this?

Something damp and sticky. Then the stench reached him.

"Uh. There was… feces on his back," a warrior said.

"…!"

"That's why we told you not to come any closer…"

His voice trailed off. Chief Jang looked from his hand to Hyuk Mujin and back again, then spoke in a low voice.

"The prisoner might shit again—no, escape. Tie the ropes tighter."

"Yes, Chief."

In the modern world, I'd been a model law-abiding citizen.

Until middle school, whenever the traffic light turned green, I would raise my hand high and cross the street. After becoming a Hunter, I paid all my insurance premiums and taxes on time, without ever delaying a payment or evading a cent.

I barely even complained about the national pension, though I'd get next to nothing from it when I grew old.

In short, prison and I had nothing to do with each other.

So why had I become so familiar with underground prisons in Murim when I hadn't committed a crime?

I'd spent time in one at the Jin Family of Taiyuan, back when I was still a budding martial artist. At the Sichuan Tang Clan, I'd stayed in one for days to remain at Jeok Cheongang's side.

This was my third visit, and it was nothing like the other two.

At the Jin Family of Taiyuan, it was practically a training hall. At the Sichuan Tang Clan, I was there for Jeok Cheongang's treatment.

Not only was I imprisoned against my will, but anyone would have thought as I did if iron balls weighing more than a thousand geun[2897] each were hanging all over their body like accessories.

Clank.

"…Fuck, these are heavy."

I muttered the curse under my breath. The enormous chains binding my limbs and the iron balls attached to them weighed so much that even I could barely move—and my Strength was far beyond human limits.

If I could use my internal energy, I might be able to figure something out…

Maybe I shouldn't have punched Baeksang at the end.

I regretted it for a moment. But if he'd been that easy to deal with, I'd be in my quarters instead of an underground prison.

Besides, even after I'd punched him hard enough to break his nose, he hadn't so much as batted an eye. He'd personally bound me while I stood there without resisting, then ordered his tribal chieftains:

"Lock the Han Chinese Jin Taekyung in the underground prison and bind him with ten thousand geun[2898] of weight."

And this was the result.

They'd put me in the deepest part of the Nanman Beast Palace's underground prison and given me a special pill that would keep me from using my internal energy for several days.

At least I should be grateful they didn't use a Pressure-Point Strike on me.

[2897] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb); ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

[2898] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb); ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

The reason was simple.

My acupoints kept coming undone.

My perfect body, which had been recognized as a Heavenly Martial Physique by countless powerful masters, had simply performed its function to the fullest.

That didn't mean I'd had any luck getting my internal energy to flow again.

"Ungh."

I tensed my whole body, took a deep breath, and focused on my lower dantian, just as I'd done hundreds, if not thousands, of times before.

The next moment, the System alert I'd been hearing over and over for the past half day sounded in my ears again.

Beep.

SYSTEM

The energy of the Force-Sealing Pill is blocking your dantian!
You cannot use internal energy!

"Ah."

I'd lost track of how many attempts I'd made. I'd given up counting after fifty.

"...Damn it."

I let myself sag with a sigh and a curse. Then footsteps approached from somewhere in the distance.

Step. Step.

They echoed through the damp darkness. The pill kept me from using my internal energy, but my senses were as sharp as ever. I raised my head and peered beyond the bars.

Splash.

The footsteps stopped in front of my cell, sending filthy water from a puddle splashing against my knees. There wasn't a single light down here, but my eyesight —good enough to rival a Mongolian's—was more than enough to make out the visitor.

"What, are you a new jailer?"

"..."

"No manners, huh? You splash dirty water on me the moment you get here, then don't even answer."

Baeksang looked down at me in silence before replying quietly.

"You complain a great deal for a criminal."

"Well, this is pretty mild, really."

I tried to shrug, flinched under the weight of the iron balls, and went on.

“Someone else had his nose broken and took it pretty well. Didn’t he?”

I could see Baeksang’s brow furrow in the darkness. The bandage wrapped around his straight, prominent nose was visible as well.

“That must’ve hurt. You held up better than I expected. Be honest—you shed a tear after sending me down here, didn’t you?”

His reaction lasted only a moment. His voice was calm when he answered.

“It tickled. Perhaps because I sensed the fear in your punch.”

“What?”

“There was no internal energy behind it, and you didn’t put your full strength into it either. It was only a child venting his frustration.”

“…”

“I understand. You must have been afraid. If you had given it everything you had, neither you nor your subordinates would have remained unharmed.”

Shit. I lost that exchange badly.

He’d hit the mark. I shut my mouth before I could come up with a reply.

Baeksang watched me, his gaze as steady as ever.

“Why didn’t you leave? If you’d fled alone, you might at least have saved your life.”

I answered with an incredulous expression.

“You said you’d cast a net over heaven and earth, you bastard.”

“And I would have. But you still had a fair chance. At the very least, the Palace Lord wouldn’t have pursued you. He might even have hindered the pursuit.”

Baeksang wasn’t making a wild guess. From what I’d seen of the Beast Miao King, and what Jeok Cheongang had told me, he was exactly the sort of man who might throw me a lifeline when things were at their worst.

But I wasn’t foolish enough to nod along. It might already have been too late, but if I readily admitted that fact in front of Baeksang, his wariness toward the Beast Miao King would only grow stronger.

“I don’t know about that. We’re not even particularly close.”

“You’re thinking, at least. But you still have a long way to go.”

“Believe what you want. Be glad Old Master isn’t here. In two or three months, your head will be rolling around this place.”

“And you’re still a child who hasn’t outgrown his rashness.”

I let out a short laugh.

“Your mouth reeks of shit. Stop sucking Dark Heaven’s asshole. At least I’m here to protect my people.”

“…”

“No one else is around, so let’s be honest. You know too, don’t you? You know what you’re doing right now.”

This time, Baeksang fell silent.

Of course he did. By working with Dark Heaven, he was handing all of Nanman over to the Lord of Heaven.

“You betrayed a sworn brother you’ve known for decades. You deceived more than thirty tribal chieftains and countless people of Nanman. There’s no excuse that could justify any of it.”

At that moment, Baeksang, who had been watching me with a deep, unreadable gaze, suddenly spoke.

“Two days.”

“What?”

“Two days. At noon, two days from now, you’ll be executed in front of everyone.”

Chapter 661

Two days from now, at noon.

And then, execution.

The two short words that slipped between Baeksang's lips shot through my mind like bullets.

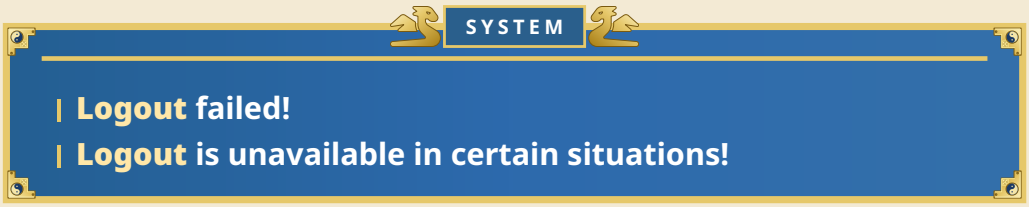
Execution in two days? Mine?

I swallowed the question rising in my throat. I couldn't let Baeksang see me shaken. Not here.

Instead of giving in to despair, I tried the escape route that had already shut me out several times.

Logout.

Beep!



Fuck. Still doesn't work.

I made myself speak calmly.

"Two days. Sooner than I expected."

"My late father always said that once you've made up your mind, you should draw your sword without hesitation."

"You're not drawing that sword alone, are you?"

"I was the first to grasp its hilt, but I won't be alone when it swings for your neck. Not even the Palace Lord can stop it."

He won't be swinging that sword alone…

I considered what he meant, then muttered almost to myself, "You must have been busy, reaching out to people all over the place in such a short time."

"Twenty tribal chieftains, including me, have already joined together," Baeksang said dryly. "And the matter on the agenda for the final day of the Tribal Grand Council will be…"

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. No—my execution, now that I'm a criminal whose sins outrage heaven and humanity."

"You understand quickly."

"I'd have to be a fucking idiot not to, with things already this far along. Anyway, is that why you threw me into the underground prison first?"

“Of course. It was the easiest way. Though I didn’t expect you to surrender so readily.”

Baeksang did not deny it. Like a hunter looking down at captured prey, he gazed at me, bound by iron balls weighing nearly ten thousand geun[2899], and continued in a low voice.

“To catch a tiger, you have to venture into the mountains and take the risk. But a tiger locked inside a cage is a different matter, wouldn’t you say?”

“I suppose so. Especially when there are twenty hunters instead of one.”

Baeksang had always had plenty of tribal chieftains behind him. But twenty?

That was more than half the thirty who remained after Heugung and Yohi disappeared. Some of the chieftains who had stood with the Beast Miao King had switched sides.

“What exactly did you promise them?”

“Revival for their tribes. Greater influence and enormous wealth.”

“Well. I figured it was something like that, but it’s damn simple.”

“But more than anything, it is effective.”

Maybe he was so candid because he knew we were alone. Whatever the reason, Baeksang was more honest today than I’d ever heard him. Worse, I couldn’t deny what he said.

The Nanman Beast Palace was an alliance of tribes. Each chieftain had sized up the situation and bet on the side most likely to win.

For the future of the tribe he ruled. For the wealth and glory he stood to gain.

And…

“The one who stands to gain the most is right in front of me. You’re going to take all of Nanman, aren’t you?”

Baeksang said nothing. I let out a hollow laugh.

“Interesting. It’s rotten right down to the roots.”

Baeksang had been watching me as though he could read my mind. Now he spoke without warning.

“Have you ever lived through a war?”

“What?”

“I asked if you have ever lived through a war.”

Why bring this up now?

I had no idea what he was after, but as the tiger in the cage, I didn’t have much choice except to listen.

“I lived through all of it. More than fifty years ago, I arrived in the Central Plains with the Palace Lord and ten thousand warriors. The first thing I saw was hell on earth.”

[2899] A Korean unit of weight. One geun is 600 g (1.32 lb); ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

He went on, slowly and evenly.

“Fields were trampled flat. Blue rivers filled with blood and corpses. Every day—every moment, it seemed—people died across the land. Children who had lost their parents to the war were so hungry they tore bark from trees and ate it without even noticing their teeth being pulled out.”

War was always horrific. Someone might win in the end, but the road to victory was strewn with screams and death. Neither side could avoid it.

“It was a hellscape unlike anything I—or even the Palace Lord—had ever seen before. But we had a reason to fight, so none of us retreated. If the Demonic Cult took control of the Central Plains, Nanman would be next. We were there to protect the homeland where my family and friends lived.”

Baeksang’s voice echoed through the dark underground prison.

“More lives were lost than I could count. Some died fighting the enemy. Others sat staring at the sky after a battle and took their own lives. Sometimes we had to strike a lethal acupoint for a comrade writhing in pain.”

“…”

“Battle after battle, some died and the rest grew weary. But as the war turned in our favor, the hope we carried grew stronger. Soon we could go home. See the women we loved, our aging parents, or the children who must have grown so much while we were away.”

I hadn’t lived through it, but I could feel it. I hadn’t seen it, but I could picture it.

Ten thousand warriors making their way through jungles, across the Yangtze, over plains and mountains, until they finally reached the distant Central Plains. Then fighting the Demonic Cult’s Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples as they surged in from every direction, day after day.

“When I stopped to count, fewer than one-tenth of the ten thousand warriors were still alive. Even the tide of battle, which had been slowly turning in our favor, eventually fell into a stalemate. The Palace Lord and I began to wonder why we had to remain there.”

Time was a law no one could oppose. Before that absolute law, which could move mountains and dry up rivers, even a master who had reached the Supreme Peak realm could do nothing.

It must have worn them down. Slowly, until they couldn’t bear any more.

As I thought it, Baeksang continued.

“Then, more than a decade into the war, the Martial God defeated the Heavenly Demon.”

The result of that life-and-death duel that shook heaven and earth was the Martial God’s victory. Once the Demonic Cult—which had devoured half the world—lost its central figure, the Heavenly Demon, it collapsed like a sandcastle.

“The remnants of the Demonic Cult retreated west. The Murim Alliance intended to pursue them to the end and wipe them out. With the Martial God—whom no one could stop now—at the fore, the Three Saints, the Ten Kings, and countless orthodox martial artists of the Murim Alliance advanced from every direction. We went with them.”

The balance had already been shifting toward the orthodox factions. With the Heavenly Demon dead, there was hardly a contest left. All they had to do was pursue the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples, now a defeated army, and root them out of the Central Plains.

“The war was as good as over. No. It should have been.”

Baeksang fell silent and stared into empty space.

Water seeped through a hairline crack in the ceiling and struck the cold floor.

Drip. Drip-drip.

I waited, but he said nothing. At last, I spoke.

“Baekhwi. Wasn’t that his name?”

“…!”

Baeksang went rigid, his eyes trembling. I’d never seen him so shaken. I gave a small nod.

“So it was. I thought I might have remembered the name wrong.”

Crunch.

Something cracked between his clenched teeth. He looked at me, his eyes cold.

“Who told you that name?”

It had been Yayul Mok, but Baeksang didn’t need to know that.

I answered calmly.

“Does that really matter? What matters is that there’s still someone who remembers the name Baekhwi.”

“Someone like you has no right to speak that name.”

Whoosh!

Blade-sharp killing intent surged from Baeksang and shot through the gaps in the iron bars.

But why?

Strangely, I wasn’t afraid.

Maybe I felt a little compassion for a father who had lost his young child long ago. Whatever else Baeksang was, that was how I felt toward him now.

Baekhwi.

Baek, white. Hwi, shining.

A person’s name. Baeksang’s only child, whom he had cherished so dearly. Someone who would have become the Beast Miao King’s son-in-law if he had lived.

If he had lived.

I muttered the words inwardly, then ignored the killing intent pouring from Baeksang and asked,

“Did he lose his life while pursuing the Demonic Cult? Or…”

Boom! Rumble!

The rest of my question vanished beneath a roar. A tremendous shock wave shook the prison.

Baeksang had pulverized a section of wall with a single punch. He stared at me with eyes like frost.

“Do you want to die here and now?”

Considering my current situation, it was a fairly threatening statement. If Hyuk Mujin had been in my place, he probably would have pissed himself and begun practicing silent meditation.

But there were exceptions. Cheongpung might be a little excited because dying would be a first for him.

And then there was me, whose liver had probably enlarged from being knocked around everywhere.

“That wouldn’t be so bad. Though you can’t kill me right now anyway.”

“What?”

“There must be a reason you put off my execution for two days. Of course, that wasn’t a decision you made alone, either. Was it an order from the Southern Heaven Demon Empress? I heard you exchange missives on the first day of every month.”

“…!”

“So stop posturing and tell me the story. Being locked alone in an underground prison gets lonely and boring. The Sichuan Tang Clan at least had other prisoners, so it wasn’t so bad.”

“You bastard!”

His shout rang through the prison. Trembling with rage, Baeksang reached out and seized the iron bars.

Creeeak!

Steel as thick as an adult’s forearm bent like taffy. Baeksang stepped through the gap, his eyes cold enough to sting.

“Hwi. Is that child’s death so amusing to you? Are you that curious?”

His aura was so vicious that it seemed he might draw his sword and cut me down at any moment.

But I did not care.

He feared the Southern Heaven Demon Empress too much to kill me here, and there was something I needed to know.

“I don’t find it amusing. But I am curious about one thing.”

“You truly—”

“Tell me.”

I cut him off in a flat voice, then continued slowly.

“Not how your only child died. I want to know what kind of lunatics turned you into one.”

“…!”

“Tell me that.”

A heavy silence followed. Every second felt like fifteen minutes before Baeksang finally opened his mouth.

“Gansu. Great Snow Mountain.”

Haa…

His breath trembled. White vapor spilled into the freezing air of the underground prison, like the heavy snow that must have fallen that day.

“Back then, we were leading the Southern Army alongside the Zhongnan Sect.”

I swallowed the words that tried to burst out of me.

Oh, fuck. The Zhongnan Sect.

Chapter 662

Was it about ten years ago? Back when I was devouring martial-arts novels, I sometimes found myself wondering.

No, more than sometimes.

What would I do if I were the protagonist of this novel?

It's a little embarrassing to think about now, but I couldn't help it. Anyone who's read enough web novels comes with that feature built in.

I'd wonder whenever some idiot protagonist had a System window but never raised his Intelligence. Or whenever a female character appeared and he made an ass of himself.

If it were me…

That was how the fantasies always began.

But once I became a martial artist in the Murim, I learned that fantasy was fantasy and reality was reality.

All those masterpieces of martial fiction I'd read were nothing more than brilliantly arranged words on a page. The protagonists I'd thought were so cool didn't exist in this world.

Old Master.

What.

There's something I've been wondering about the Heavenly Demon. His surname wouldn't happen to be Muk, would it?

…What the hell are you talking about all of a sudden? Not long ago, you were spouting off about things like the Wudang Demon Sword and the Huashan Gale Sword—titles I've never heard of in my life.

At first, I was sorry I'd never get to meet the protagonists from those novels, but I wasn't disappointed. The martial artists of this world were pretty damn cool in their own right.

If anything had thoroughly shattered my fantasies, though, it was…

"We were leading the Southern Army alongside the Zhongnan Sect at the time."

Right. Those three words that had just come out of Baeksang's mouth.

The Zhongnan Sect.

A towering pillar of the orthodox Murim. One of the Nine Sects and One Gang. A prestigious sect that had endured for hundreds of years and shared Shaanxi Province with its eternal rival, Huashan.

No—I should probably say they *used to* share it.

The Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, who had remained hidden from the world for so many years, was now the Alliance Leader. The Disciple he had taken in during his

later years had gained tremendous fame, and as a result, the influence of their sect, Huashan, had grown to an extent that could not be compared to the past.

And the Zhongnan Sect?

Two of its three Supreme Peak masters are laid up and wheezing.

Jeok Cheongang had crushed the Roaring Fury Swordsman, and I'd crushed the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

At least Hyuk Sopyung, the young prodigy around my age known as the Zhongnan One Dragon, was a fairly decent guy. But so far, my impression of the Zhongnan Sect had been anything but good.

No. At least among the orthodox factions, it was the worst.

With higher-ups like that, they can forget about The Reign.

At this point, calling it the *Fucknam Sect*—or the *Zhong-fucking-na Sect*—would hardly be an exaggeration.

Well, the current Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, might be different. But from everything I'd seen and heard in the Murim, my opinion of the Zhongnan Sect didn't seem far from everyone else's.

And now the Zhongnan Sect comes up in this story…

I could feel it. I could feel something coming.

Just as I unconsciously furrowed my brow, Baeksang continued speaking.

"The Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect at the time, Venerable Wusang, was righteous and wise. He stayed calm no matter what happened and treated everyone fairly, regardless of their background. That was why the Palace Lord and I agreed that he should command the Southern Army."

"Venerable Wusang…"

"Yes. He was the master of the Zhongnan Sect's current Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord."

I'd heard Jeok Cheongang mention the title a few times.

Granted, Jeok Cheongang usually called the Zhongnan Sect "a bunch of ill-mannered sons of bitches." But even he'd described Venerable Wusang as "soft, but a fine man."

"The trouble began soon after we entered Gansu. Defeated soldiers from the surrounding areas, who had been retreating in disarray, gathered at Great Snow Mountain. There were no fewer than two thousand of them."

"…How the hell did two thousand defeated soldiers turn up in the surrounding area?"

"Do you think they were called the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples for nothing? They had lost the Heavenly Demon, but their numbers were still nothing to dismiss."

"So what happened? Was there a battle at Great Snow Mountain?"

Baeksang slowly nodded.

“It was a battle we had every reason to win. At the time, the Western Army we belonged to had Venerable Wusang, a Supreme Peak master, as well as the Palace Lord, who had only just begun to be called the Beast Miao King. We were not inferior in either the number or the quality of our troops. If anything, we had a considerable advantage.”

“Sounds like the Western Army was pretty large.”

“Over four thousand in all. The enemy had no Supreme Peak master of note, so we had no reason to avoid the fight.”

“Hmm.”

Two Supreme Peak masters the enemy didn’t have. More than twice as many troops. And they were facing a defeated force already worn down by exhaustion and despair.

Anyone could see how that fight ought to end.

But if it had been that easy, Baeksang wouldn’t have lost his only son.

“There was a trap?”

Baeksang answered my sudden question in a voice as dry as sand.

“Yes. We split into three groups and advanced into Great Snow Mountain. What awaited us wasn’t a band of defeated soldiers, but an elite strike force of the Demonic Cult.”

“…!”

“It was chaos from beginning to end. Arrows poured down like rain from above the gorge, while rocks weighing hundreds or thousands of geun[2900] crushed people and blocked the narrow paths.”

“…”

“By the time we knew it was a trap, it was too late. We fought desperately. Then I looked up and realized someone who should always have been at my side was gone.”

He didn’t say the name, but I knew he wasn’t talking about the Beast Miao King.

Baekhwi.

Baeksang’s only child. The heir who would inherit everything he had.

To set an example as a great chieftain, he had taken his young child with him to the battlefield. But he had probably cherished his son more than his own life.

And then, on a battlefield painted with corpses and blood, the fine young man he had raised had vanished without a trace during the final battle.

“For the first time, I was afraid. Hwi… That child was everything to me. No, more than that.”

Baeksang’s voice was hollow.

[2900] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb).

“But I had to regain my composure, if only for the warriors under my command. First, I requested support from the Zhongnan Sect and the other orthodox martial artists who had entered the area not far away. Then I helped the Palace Lord fight the enemy.”

The ambush had caught them by surprise. The fighting had been fierce, but the Beast Miao King, Baeksang, and the Nanman warriors had refused to retreat.

They fought harder than ever and finally won, though it cost them countless lives.

“Only after the battle in the gorge ended did I learn where he had gone. He and dozens of warriors had pursued some of the enemy down a side path. I was relieved.”

“Why?” I asked.

“The path connected to territory that definitely belonged to our allies. I believed that the people who had received my request for support would have saved Hwi—that child.”

“…”

I closed my mouth.

It wasn’t anger or grief that broke a person. It was trust.

And when that trust was betrayed, despair followed. I could see it in Baeksang now.

“What do you think happened?”

I didn’t answer. He probably hadn’t expected me to. After a moment, he went on.

“He… didn’t even leave a body behind. The corpses of the warriors who went with him lay scattered everywhere, hacked apart by an enemy we couldn’t identify. Only later did I learn it was the Great Snow Fiend, the fiend who ruled Great Snow Mountain.”

“…!”

“Reinforcements? There were no such things. They said the messenger who had set out to request support had been killed by the enemy while on his way to the other allied forces. I was overwhelmed by grief and despair, unable to do anything. And it was only later that I learned the truth.”

At that moment, Baeksang’s entire body trembled.

And I saw an emotion rise in eyes that had always been cold and still.

“The messenger wasn’t killed by the enemy. He was killed by our allies.”

Anger. Hatred.

“They weren’t unable to help us. They chose not to.”

It was the quiet, desperate scream of a man whose trust had been betrayed.

“If they had come, he could have lived. But they did not come. They killed the messenger, ignored my desperate request, and chose to pursue the retreating enemy instead. Do you know why?”

What pools up will eventually overflow. Baeksang had spent decades letting it out, yet the hatred and betrayal kept filling him until they spilled over again.

As they did now.

“Because we were nothing but savages from the Outer Lands!”

“…!”

“Because we weren’t Han Chinese like them, could never become Han Chinese, and they couldn’t sacrifice themselves for savages like us!”

Boom! Crash!

A powerful, violent wave of energy whipped through the air.

The floor and walls, made from solid rock, crumbled. Streams of tangible internal energy poured from his fist and grazed my face.

Ssst!

A sharp pain stung my forehead. I felt hot blood run down it.

But I didn’t move. I only watched, waiting until Baeksang’s eyes, flashing with killing intent, turned toward me.

“The Central Plains—the Han Chinese—betrayed us. We reached out to them when they were most desperate, and after we’d fought for them at the risk of our lives for ten years, they betrayed us!”

Decades of hatred were aimed squarely at me.

Only then did I open my mouth.

“Why didn’t you tell Venerable Wusang? He would’ve brought everything to light.”

“Venerable Wusang?”

Baeksang laughed. It was the first time I’d heard him laugh, and the sound was so empty it hardly counted.

“Yes. He would have. If he’d been alive.”

“You mean…”

“His Internal Injury had flared up before the battle. He fought anyway, and the Great Snow Fiend killed him. Enraged by his death, the Zhongnan Sect killed the messenger we sent, ignored our request for help, and pursued the enemy. The dozens of other sects, large and small, assigned to the Western Army did the same.”

“What?”

“You find it hard to believe? So did I. Only one person—the Palace Lord—tried to uncover the truth of it all. But when the Great Faction War ended, every pretense and every ugly stain was buried with it.”

“…!”

“Then, while everyone but us basked in victory and peace, the messenger’s body disappeared from where it had been kept. The last piece of evidence, bearing traces of the Zhongnan Sect’s martial arts, was gone.”

These fucking lunatics.

I swallowed a groan.

I could barely breathe. If Baeksang was telling the truth, no one—not even me—could condemn his anger.

He'd fought with his life on the line, and betrayal was all he got in return.

The most fucked-up part of all this was the instinctive certainty that this long-ago incident, which had left behind not even a shred of evidence, had probably really happened.

Damn it.

When I first came to the Murim, I'd been counted among the Han Chinese. I knew how people from the Central Plains looked at the people of Nanman.

I knew how shallow human feelings could be, and how easily greed took hold.

Baeksang had kept fighting for victory even after his son disappeared. The allies he trusted hadn't done the same.

Enraged by Venerable Wusang's death, the Zhongnan Sect had ignored the Nanman Beast Palace's plea and chased the enemy. The other sects of the Western Army had been blinded by fear of losing their own men and greed for credit.

And the result of everything they'd done was standing right in front of me.

"You said earlier that this land—Nanman—was rotten."

Drip. Trickle.

In the aftermath of what had just happened, foul-smelling water poured from the cracked ceiling.

Beyond the falling water, Baeksang's eyes gleamed coldly.

"That day, you people showed me what I had to do."

Chapter 663

"That day, you people showed me which path I should take."

With those words spat out in a bitter voice, his story—neither short nor long—came to an end. I silently stared into Baeksang's coldly gleaming eyes.

What did I want to say to him?

I wasn't sure.

The man standing before me in dazzling white robes had lived through a darkness I couldn't begin to imagine. He had fought for a righteous cause, only to be betrayed. He had lost the child he cherished more than his own life.

There could only be one reason he had kept living.

Revenge.

Baeksang wasn't wrong. After he lost his only child, the betrayal of the Central Plains people had lit a torch in the darkness where he wandered. By its light, he'd found the only path he could see.

The path of revenge.

He had followed that thorny road of pain and fury all the way here. Looking at him, I suddenly remembered someone else.

"…The Head Elder."

Confusion flickered in Baeksang's eyes at my involuntary mutter. I clicked my tongue bitterly.

"It's nothing. You just reminded me of someone I used to know."

"How so?"

"He was a fucking idiot, too. Just like you. A puppet controlled by Dark Heaven."

"What?"

"But I could understand him. He had his reasons."

"…He was betrayed."

"Yeah. By his own flesh and blood."

Baeksang looked down at me in silence. Then he asked, "What happened to him?"

"I killed him. With my own hands."

"…!"

"He was an elder of my family, but I had no choice. Things had already gone too far."

"Do you wish to condemn me?"

I let out a short laugh.

Condemn him? What would that change now?

"Condemning someone with words alone doesn't do a damn thing. It wouldn't stop you. That was the main reason I had to kill the Head Elder."

That was how an avenger met his end.

They stepped onto a path they had never wanted to take, then lost their way forever. They were like moths rushing toward a single torch—the torch of revenge.

“After I killed him, I wondered something. If the Jin Family of Taiyuan and I had lost that battle… would getting his revenge have finally made him happy?”

“That…”

“Probably not. He lived only for revenge, but at some point, his anger must have dulled, and watching innocent people be sacrificed must have left him feeling guilty.”

I didn’t wait for Baeksang to answer.

“Just like you do now.”

“…!”

I calmly looked into Baeksang’s twisted face.

“I definitely don’t understand you. I’ve never gone through what you did, and I’ve never burned with revenge for decades. But at the same time, I admit it. At least as far as I’m concerned, your anger toward the Central Plains people and the Han Chinese is justified.”

“Justified?” Baeksang repeated, his face rigid.

He clearly hadn’t expected that answer, but I meant every word. I meant what I said next, too.

“Yeah. I would’ve done the same thing if I were you. No—if I had been in your place, perhaps the entire Central Plains would already have been my enemy.”

I remembered the day I’d gone to the Ares Guild.

I had been alone then, but there hadn’t been the slightest hesitation in my steps.

It wasn’t because I had possessed enough strength to make that choice. It was because I had been genuinely furious over Kim Hwajong’s death.

And I had brought down the Ares Guild.

If I’d been Baeksang instead of Jin Taekyung, I would have fought to bring down the Central Plains.

But…

“Is that anger of yours justified toward the people of Nanman, too?”

“…!”

“Some of them might understand you. But what did the people killed because you joined forces with Dark Heaven do wrong? What about their families? Their lovers and friends?”

Baeksang jerked. I kept my voice steady.

“When I first set foot in Nanman, I heard some news. A Miao village had been massacred by a group of Han Chinese. Those Han Chinese had slaughtered a

hundred people, men, women, and children alike, but in the end, both sides had been destroyed by poison."

Being locked alone in an underground prison gave me plenty of time to think. I'd gone over everything that had happened since I arrived, and I was certain of one thing.

"No matter how I look at it, it's strange. Even if there was a fight, how did not one person survive?"

It had been planned from the beginning. Wipe out a Miao village, and hostility toward the Han Chinese would boil over across all of Nanman.

"And that's not all. There were the Thousand-Year Spiders suddenly leaving the Poisonblood Grounds, and what happened at the Western Yao Estate. Add the Miao village, and the dead number well over three hundred."

All that had happened in just seven days and nights since I came to the Nanman Beast Palace. Compared with the decades Baeksang had spent consumed by revenge, it was barely any time at all.

What frightened me more was what lay ahead. If Baeksang was to have his revenge in full, war with the Central Plains wasn't merely possible. It was inevitable.

"Just how…"

I looked at him, torn between pity and anger.

How much more blood are you going to spill, Baeksang?

Splash. Splash.

With each step, foul water long pooled on the prison floor splashed in every direction. The man walking through it paid no attention to his snow-white robes getting dirty.

No—his mind was so full that he hadn't noticed.

Splash…

His already-soaked leather shoes came to an abrupt stop.

While crossing the underground prison alone, the middle-aged man, Baeksang, suddenly looked back over his shoulder.

Dark. Cold. Silent.

Like the path he had walked. Like the path the man imprisoned behind him would have to walk.

But Jin Taekyung would never walk as far as he had. Only two days remained until his public execution. Baeksang's path had stretched across decades; Jin Taekyung's was short, with its end in plain sight.

It's as good as over. He won't escape.

Baeksang already knew roughly how skilled Jin Taekyung was. A Supreme Peak master who stood out even in the Central Plains, where countless prestigious sects had taken root.

Baeksang hadn't used his full strength when they briefly exchanged moves a few days ago. Still, he had known instinctively.

Half a move above me. No… perhaps a full move.

Jin Taekyung was a monster beyond anything Baeksang had imagined. But with his internal energy sealed and iron balls of enormous weight restraining him, he couldn't survive even if his master, the Fire King, came for him.

Besides, something bound him more tightly than the iron balls.

The Han Chinese under his command.

Jin Taekyung cared about his people. That was why he had surrendered and allowed himself to be imprisoned instead of escaping.

What a fool.

In Baeksang's eyes, compassion was the monstrous young man's greatest weakness. Nothing made a martial artist less like a martial artist.

And yet nothing made a person more human.

On the day blood stained the snow of Great Snow Mountain, that was what Baeksang had so desperately wanted from his allies.

Come to think of it, Hwi was about his age then.

Baeksang stared blankly into the empty air. In the darkness where nothing existed, a face briefly passed through his mind.

An infant becoming a boy. A boy becoming a young man.

His only child, more upright than anyone, who had shone as brightly as his name, Hwi.[2901]

The smiling face of the child he would never see again.

Crunch.

Without realizing it, Baeksang clenched his fist tightly. His neatly trimmed nails dug into his flesh, and blood began to flow.

Drip. Drip-drip.

He looked down. Red drops spread through the stagnant water around his feet. Each small ripple traced the outline of a face.

How much more blood are you going to spill, Baeksang?

Jin Taekyung's last words kept ringing in his ears. But Baeksang's answer was the same now as it had been then.

I crossed that river long ago. I can never go back.

He had crossed that river a long time ago.

[2901] *Hwi* (□) means "shining."

Half-mad with despair and rage, Baeksang had met a beautiful woman whose identity he did not know. She had offered him something more alluring than her looks.

No. Something he could not refuse.

Choose. Do so, and it will surely come to pass.

He hadn't hesitated. With a purpose to live for, he had gladly taken her outstretched hand. He had never once regretted that decision.

No. He must not regret it.

But why…?

With the fruit of all those decades almost within his grasp, why was he wavering now?

Baeksang swallowed the sound rising in his throat and gritted his teeth. He looked at his filthy leather shoes and the hems of robes that could no longer be called white.

In two days. Everything ends. Everything.

At his feet, drops of blood spread through the pooled water. Dirty long before his blood touched it, the water slowly turned red.

Like the path he had walked. Like the path still ahead of him.

Splash.

Baeksang stamped through the puddle and started walking again, Jin Taekyung's voice still echoing in his ears through the silence.

Baeksang left, and I was alone again.

The chains pulled taut around me, and the iron balls weighing ten thousand geun[2902] held me fast. My whole body was growing stiff.

Damn.

Now that he was gone, I kind of wished he'd stayed. Maybe I should have begged him to spare me.

Still, I didn't regret it. I'd said everything I needed to say, and groveling for my life wouldn't have gotten me anywhere. Baeksang had lived for revenge alone. He wasn't going to tear up like an auntie watching a human-interest documentary just because I begged him.

That didn't mean I planned to let them drag me out in two days and quietly put me to death.

Are you crazy? I have to survive somehow.

[2902] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg (about 13,200 lb).

I'd meant it when I said his anger was justified. That didn't mean I deserved to die at his hands. As far as I was concerned, the Head Elder and Baeksang were both idiots with tragic stories.

And I intended to stop this new idiot I had met after traveling all the way to a foreign land, no matter what it took.

But how do I get out?

All that talking and thinking had left my throat dry. I was swallowing what little spit I had when something cold touched the top of my head.

Tap.

"Huh?"

It was water. It might have been stale and tasteless, but the important thing was that it was water. The ceiling had probably opened up farther when Baeksang smashed the surrounding walls.

Well, that helps.

I muttered inwardly and tilted my head back toward the ceiling.

The next moment, through the crack in the ceiling, I found myself looking into a pair of eyes I hadn't expected to see.

Huge, clear eyes like a calf's.

"…Why are you up there?"

Their owner answered.

"Taishan. Hungry. Got locked in underground prison because they said Taishan eats too much."

"Ah."

Fair enough.

Chapter 664

Unlike modern prisons, where human rights have been mixed in just enough to make them palatable, underground prisons in the Murim served their purpose exceptionally well.

The concept of human rights didn't exist here in the first place.

The underground prison of the Sichuan Tang Clan, for example, had been closer to a torture chamber than a place meant to hold prisoners.

Even the old guard who had died during Dark Heaven's attack had been a torture expert with decades of experience. He would often reminisce about his prime with a pleased smile.

"Those days right after the Great Faction War were wonderful. We had three or four head of notorious fiends brought in every day."

"…Head? Not people?"

"Yes. When we lined up fifteen or so of the beasts and got to work, the response was incredible. They were so happy they nearly passed out."

He even counted people the way you counted animals.

I had never bothered to ask for details, but it was hard to imagine prisoners screaming with delight because he'd given them pretty irezumi tattoos with the small knife he kept tucked so carefully into his belt.

Like hell they were tattoos.

It was obvious.

Bones and flesh splitting apart, blood spraying everywhere—something like that.

I'd gone a little off track. Anyway, most underground prisons in the Murim were more or less the same.

Cold, damp, and nine times out of ten, buried deep underground.

Just like the underground prison of the Nanman Beast Palace where I was locked up. And…

"Pavilion Master. Taishan hungry. Got locked in underground prison because Taishan eats too much."

"Ah."

The difference between me and that accursed bastard was only one floor.

The third and fourth underground floors, for example.

So this is how it turned out.

In a way, it was a coincidence born of an aging, poorly built prison taking a considerable blow.

I stared blankly at the ceiling, then gave a quiet laugh at Taishan, who was blinking his enormous eyes through the small hole above me.

"Pavilion Master, why laugh?"

“Because I’m happy to see you.”

“Happy? Pavilion Master happy to see Taishan?”

“Yeah, you bastard. I’m so happy I could die.”

“Oh. Then Taishan happy to see Pavilion Master too.”

It was a conversation that made no sense out of context, but every time I saw his eyes peering through the gap, I couldn’t help laughing.

Seeing a familiar face was one thing. If things went well, I might be able to get out of here sooner than expected.

Besides, Taishan was the only person who could answer the question worrying me most.

“What about everyone else? They’re all doing okay, right?”

At my question, his enormous calf-like eyes filled with tears.

“Are you… crying?”

“Sniff. Pavilion Master.”

No way.

Dread hit me. I hurried to ask, “Stop sniveling and tell me what happened.”

“Taishan… sniff. Couldn’t help it. It’s so unfair.”

“…!”

Damn it. My vision went dark. I could already picture the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion lying there as cold corpses.

Or were they tortured? But how could they do that?

It had only been half a day since I’d surrendered on the condition that the Fire Dragon Pavilion members would be kept safe.

The Beast Miao King himself had promised me. No matter how powerful Baeksang’s faction had become, they couldn’t do this.

If they were harmed, then what the hell did I surrender for…?

Just as the thought ran hollowly through my head, Taishan spoke through his tears.

“I still can’t believe it. By now, everyone must be eating without Taishan.”

“…?”

“Taishan hates Lord. Hates Namho too. It’s so unfair.”

“…!”

“Pavilion Master. Speaking of which, do you have anything to eat?”

What the hell was going on?

I fell silent for a moment, then answered from the bottom of my heart.

“No, you fucking bastard.”

“Aw. Taishan hungry.”

“…Come down. Come down right now.”

That son of a bitch. He really wanted to die.

My blood pressure shot up, and rage took over my entire body. I thrashed harder than I had at any point since being locked in the underground prison.

Clatter! Clank!

If not for these goddamn heavy iron balls, I would have started by punching that bastard in the mouth.

Taishan watched me panting with interest before speaking.

“Namho and Lord are doing well. They’re being held in different places, so Taishan doesn’t know much, but White Tiger’s master told Taishan.”

“White Tiger’s master? Yayul Mok?”

“Oh. Taishan remembers. Right. Yayul Mok.”

It seemed the Beast Miao King had stepped in after all. I stopped thrashing and let out a sigh of relief.

“You should’ve said that first, you lunatic. You nearly gave me a heart attack.”

“Taishan hasn’t eaten for two whole shichen.[2903] Taishan’s mind is hazy.”

“…People don’t usually call it hunger after two shichen.[2904] More importantly, how did you end up locked in here? Great Hero Yayul would’ve stopped it before it got this far. There’s no way you were locked up just for eating too much.”

“Taishan was treated unfairly. A Nanman man was going to leave after giving Taishan a mouse-dropping-sized portion of food. Taishan grabbed his wrist to ask for more, and the bone broke.”

“…”

“Taishan was surprised and grabbed his other wrist. That one broke too. It was obviously a trap.”

Clatter! Clank! Clank!

“Pavilion Master, calm down. Taishan was angry too, but Taishan held it in and surrendered, just like Pavilion Master.”

“…Come down. This time, really come down.”

I was already trying to keep a low profile, and this bastard had broken both arms of the man who came to feed him?

At this rate, I was going to die of rage before noon two days from now.

I walked into the tiger’s den to save a bastard like that?

I barely managed to calm my anger before asking, “Then what about the others? Not Namho or Sama Pyo. Everyone else?”

“Hmm. Ah.”

Taishan rolled his enormous eyes around as he thought, then answered.

“I heard they were captured.”

[2903] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

[2904] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

"Captured?"

"Yeah. But they said they weren't coming here. Taishan doesn't know why, but White Tiger's master said it was safer that way."

Ju Hwaran, Song Ilseom, and Hyuk Mujin.

For a moment, my heart sank at the news that all three had been captured. But I agreed with Yayul Mok that it was much safer that way.

Baeksang's influence can't reach that far right now.

The two tribal chieftains leading the squad were loyal to the Beast Miao King. Some of the Nanman people I'd rescued from the Poisonblood Grounds were their kinsmen, too. Unlike the other chieftains who had gone over to Baeksang, they wouldn't switch sides easily.

The three of them are more likely to be in danger than they are now if the reconnaissance squad runs into the Blood Monk.

The Blood Monk was an unidentified old monster who had stained Guizhou with blood single-handedly, wielding Supreme Peak martial prowess.

Almost nothing was known about him. But if he really was a subordinate of the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, as I suspected, things could take the worst possible turn.

He would certainly head south on the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's orders. And if he encountered the reconnaissance squad, the three people among them would fall into his hands as well.

"...Damn it."

But for now, I had no time to worry about that.

They were on the move even now, while I was trapped deep underground, unable to move an inch.

All I can do is hope I'm wrong about the Blood Monk.

So there were only two things I could do.

The first was prayer.

The second was...

Escape.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A new Quest has been generated!
Would you like to check the linked Quest, Escape from Namshank?[2905]
Y / N

[2905] "Namshank" plays on *The Shawshank Redemption* and Nanman.

I nodded and thought, *I don't know who developed the System, but that's one shitty Quest title.*

"So, Pavilion Master. Do you have anything to eat?"

...Correction. *That* bastard was the shittiest of all.

Among the countless martial artists on the continent, river pirates were an especially rough and free-spirited bunch.

They didn't want laws restricting them or the authorities arresting them. They didn't want to live decent lives, either.

Sudal, the Deputy Stronghold Lord of the Water Dragon Stronghold, had become a river pirate for exactly those reasons.

Unlike his father, who had lived and died a good fisherman, Sudal had boldly resolved to live and die as an adventurer.

He'd done fairly well as a river pirate. Only recently had he begun to wonder what he was doing with his life.

What the hell am I doing?

Nothing. Every day, he sat at the bow and stared at the calm river. When the sun got too hot, he went swimming. That was all.

His immediate superior, who ruled the Yangtze in Sichuan, had been summoned to League headquarters by the revered Alliance Leader. Meanwhile, Sudal and his men had come down the tributaries to backwater Yunnan and were wasting their days.

By now, merchant ships loaded with all kinds of valuable goods must be traveling through Sichuan.

The Yangtze was a gold mine right now. With war approaching, all sorts of supplies were moving along it.

Sudal knew that and desperately wanted to return immediately. But every time he did, one man's presence kept flashing before his eyes.

"I'll come running whenever you call!"

That was the boast he'd made seven days and nights ago. Naturally, he hadn't meant a word of it.

But the much younger man had smiled warmly and answered,

"Oh, good. Then stay nearby."

"Excuse me?"

"Heh heh. Did someone stick a marlin in your ear? I said stay nearby. I'll need another favor when we head back."

"Great Hero Jin, forgive me, but we have a living to make..."

"A living. That's nice. But you have to be alive to make one, don't you?"

"…!"

"Come on, I'm asking a favor! Just a favor!"

"Gasp."

"For fuck's sake. I might just snap every mast and burn the whole lot down. Want to swim to Sichuan?"

He called it a favor, but it was a threat.

What could Sudal do? In the Murim, whoever had the stronger martial arts was king.

Worse, that monstrous young man's Master was a crazy old monster who really was called a king.

Jin Taekyung, you bastard…

Swallowing his tears, Sudal had nodded. For more than seven days and nights, he and his men had stayed on a tributary at the edge of Yunnan where they couldn't even spot a small boat, doing nothing but catching fish.

Until an idea occurred to him yesterday.

Wait. Why am I doing this? It'll be a while before that Jin Taekyung bastard comes back.

Sudal had only ever operated on the Yangtze, but even he knew what a godforsaken dump Nanman was.

He didn't know exactly what Jin Taekyung's mission was. Still, if it had brought him all the way here, it couldn't be simple.

But did he really need to worry about someone who wasn't even here and whine like a dog that needed to shit?

He gave his adventurous life some serious thought, then ordered his men,

"Hey, boys. Let's go get some fresh air."

"Excuse me?"

"Where?"

"Guizhou's right next door. Let's make a sweep through it, raid the place, and come back."

His ambitious plan didn't go over well.

"Deputy Stronghold Lord, have you lost your mind?"

"Fuck. If you want to die, die alone. Why should the rest of us get cremated when you're not even the Stronghold Lord?"

But Sudal had a plan for that, too.

"Dunk that bastard. The Yangtze… the Yangtze…"

"The Yangtze dip?"

"Yeah. That thing Jin Taekyung does all the time."

After sending two of them into the water one after another, the complaints disappeared. Under Sudal's spirited command, three swift ships traveled along the western tributary toward Guizhou.

At last, after all this time, they found a target.

Just like now.

"There's a ship roughly two hundred zhang[2906] ahead!"

"Seize it! Don't let it get away!"

How long had it been since their last raid? Sudal stood tall at the stern like a Great General, smiling with satisfaction as the ship drew rapidly closer.

Then, before fifteen minutes had passed, he realized something was wrong.

Whoosh!

The ship was almost upon them now. There was no crew and no captain.

Only one person waited for them.

"A swift ship of the Yangtze River Channel League. What fortunate timing."

"…!"

The bald, middle-aged man holding a blood-soaked Zen staff smiled broadly at the frozen Sudal.

"Does this ship go to Nanman too?"

[2906] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Two hundred zhang are about 606 m (1,990 ft).

Chapter 665

Tap. Drip-drip.

Water dripped through the silence. I shifted away from the liquid falling through a crack in the underground prison's ceiling and looked into the air before me.

SYSTEM

Quest
Escape from Namshank[2907]
You have ended up imprisoned in the underground prison of the Nanman Beast Palace after all. Dark, damp, and silent, this place resembles the future that awaits you. But it is still too soon to give up on life.
Time remaining until execution: Two days
You must escape the underground prison within the allotted time.
Whether you survive alone or together is entirely up to you. If you fail, only death awaits.
But remember: with a strong Will and even a single thread of goodwill, a path to life will open.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Escape the underground prison before the execution (Incomplete)
Reward: Linked Quest
???
Failure: Death

I had already checked the Quest window countless times.

I stared at the translucent holographic window as if I could bore a hole through it, but no miracle occurred that changed the words written on the final line.

Failure: Death.

It wasn't the first time.

From the moment I first set foot in the Murim until now, I had received this kind of goddamn Quest several times. Of course, in the beginning, I had been utterly dumbfounded.

Back then, I really thought I was going to die a dog's death.

I'd fought countless battles as a Hunter, but death had always frightened me. Or rather, what frightened me was everything I'd have to leave behind.

[2907] "Namshank" is a play on the title of *The Shawshank Redemption*.

At least if I died in a Gate, my family would get a death benefit. If I died in Murim, they'd get nothing.

Still, there was no comparing who I'd been then to who I was now. Every crisis had given my guts a forced Botox injection. They'd grown bigger by the day, and my body and mind had toughened along with them.

But…

I've never been in a situation like this.

There was a simple reason I'd survived every brush with death. I'd either had someone beside me to fight with, or, when I had to face an enemy alone, I'd been ready to put my life on the line.

I'd fought and struggled to the bitter end. And I'd survived.

Clatter.

But never with enormous iron balls hanging all over my body and my internal energy sealed.

"…Damn it."

I muttered under my breath and closed my eyes. The words from the Quest description seemed to appear against the darkness.

With a strong Will and even a single thread of goodwill, a path to life will open.

The System sometimes sent me messages I couldn't tell apart from hints or complete nonsense. Was this just encouragement? Or was it the clue I needed to escape?

As I sat there thinking with my eyes closed, liquid fell from above, struck the floor, and splashed onto the back of my hand.

Tap. Splatter.

It was too sticky to be groundwater, and its temperature was warm enough to make me feel grimy.

I opened my eyes at once, but without even looking at the ceiling, I spoke.

"…You crazy bastard. I told you to quit drooling."

I heard a slurp as Taishan swallowed.

"Sorry. Taishan was too hungry."

"If you're hungry, why are you putting your mouth against a hole in the floor? Just sit still."

"But if Taishan keeps licking, it's surprisingly salty."

"Licking? What?"

"Rock. This place is a rock restaurant."

"Oh, for crying out loud."

"Crying out loud? Is that some kind of sauce?"

This crazy bastard…

I swallowed the curse rising in my throat. Getting angry at him would only waste what little energy I had. It wouldn't change anything.

Besides, Taishan wasn't in much better shape than I was. I had no idea what sort of creature he was made of—his vital points were so thick that the Pressure-Point Strike hadn't worked—but his internal energy had been sealed, and his whole body was bound. Even Taishan's natural strength couldn't get him out of that.

"Pavilion Master. Taishan hungry. Taishan wants to get out soon."

Listening to his quiet whining, I suddenly felt something that could only be called guilt.

This is all my fault.

"…Hey, Taishan."

"Pavilion Master. Why did you call Taishan?"

"I'm sorry."

"Huh?"

"I'm sorry. I mean it."

I looked up as I spoke. Through a hole the size of a child's fist, I could see one enormous, clear eye, like a calf's.

It held a look of complete bewilderment.

I'd always thought Taishan had a heart far more innocent than his age or size suggested. He was like a clean sheet of paper.

I sighed.

"I should've made a better call. I didn't. I made a mistake."

A painful misjudgment. In baduk[2908] terms, a terrible move.

I had locked myself inside the underground prison to clean up the consequences of that mistake, but… damn it. I still had doubts about whether it had really been the right choice.

Taishan studied me as if I'd said something strange.

"Taishan is okay."

"You're okay?"

"Mm-hmm. Taishan is really okay."

"…"

I lowered my head. He probably didn't even understand what was happening. Right now, the most important thing to him was that he was hungry. The second most important was that he had no way to do anything about it.

Maybe that's better for him.

Then he spoke again, and I realized he was far sharper than I'd given him credit for.

[2908] Baduk is the Korean name for Go, a strategy board game.

"Pavilion Master doesn't need to feel sorry for Taishan."

"…?"

I looked up in surprise. Taishan met my eyes and spoke clearly.

"Taishan knows. Taishan is stupid."

"What?"

"Ever since Taishan was little, people called him stupid and made fun of him. They came and hit him whenever they were bored. If Taishan hadn't met Lord… maybe someone would still hit Taishan every day, and Taishan would cry. It was hard."

This wasn't the Taishan I was used to. His whole manner had changed, and his words flowed without a pause as I stared up at him.

"But Lord was different. Even when Taishan said something wrong, Lord understood. When Taishan ate a lot, Lord patted him on the back and told him to eat slowly. So Taishan decided to give his life to Lord."

"You…"

"Then, a little while ago, Lord told Taishan we should trust Pavilion Master. He said Pavilion Master seemed different from the other people in the orthodox faction. Thinking about it now, Lord was right. A few days ago, when stupid Taishan couldn't save Lord, Pavilion Master did."

"…!"

"Taishan likes the Fire Dragon Pavilion now. Taishan likes little, cute Namho, and Hyuk Mujin, even if he's annoying sometimes. Taishan likes fierce Song Ilseom and Ju Hwaran, who's pretty as a flower. And after Lord, Taishan likes Pavilion Master best."

I was speechless. Beyond the hole, his eye curved gently.

"Taishan trusts Lord, and Lord trusts the Pavilion Master. So Pavilion Master, trust yourself. The Pavilion Master will definitely find a way. Just like always."

Taishan gave a little giggle. For a while, all I could do was stare.

It felt as if someone had hit me in the back of the head with a club. I'd never expected Taishan, of all people, to say those things.

And I'd never expected his words to give me more strength than anything else could right now.

Yeah. Come to think of it, there's always been a way.

In the Murim, I seemed to have lived a life rather close to death.

Jopil. The Head Elder. The Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Blood Lord. The Western Heaven Demon Lord…

Danger had waited wherever I went. Each time, I'd taken the word *death* from where I kept it buried in my heart, turned it over, and made myself a promise.

I would never die. I could never die here.

A strong Will.

Was that what the Quest meant? Or…

Something else connected to a strong Will.

A certain thing the Slaughter Saint had said to me in Hubei just a few months ago flashed through my mind like lightning.

“Huh. You monstrous bastard. You finally opened your Middle Dantian, so now you can handle qi properly.”

I’d asked him, “I already know how to handle it. Don’t you know how much internal energy I have?”

The Slaughter Saint had merely let out a short laugh without answering. Then he had shaken his head and disappeared, saying I wouldn’t understand even if he told me now.

But now I thought I was beginning to understand why he’d said it. How ridiculous I must have looked to him: a young fool boasting that he could handle qi because he had several jiazi[2909] of internal energy.

The Three Dantians.

The three greatest and most important passages in the human body.

But the Lower Dantian was only a vessel, filled and emptied of internal energy again and again. I hadn’t grasped even a quarter of what the Middle Dantian could do or how it worked.

Now, though, things were different.

No. I understood a little.

It wasn’t internal energy that moved the Middle Dantian.

It was Will.

Strong, unwavering Will.

The Middle Dantian had belonged to the realm of enlightenment from the start, not internal energy.

It lay somewhere in an unknown domain, half a step beyond even those chosen masters whose limits were no longer decided by how much internal energy they possessed. A sacred realm one had to pass through to rise from human birth toward the realm of gods.

Since martial arts had first appeared in this world, countless masters must have met success or failure along this path. Some had crumbled like dry leaves. Others had become giants who left their footprints on the long history of martial arts.

And today, I took half a step closer to those giants.

Whoosh.

As if entranced, I reached out. Hidden among the air around me, the qi of the world rippled toward my fingertips.

[2909] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

Just as Baeksang was about to enter his quarters, he sensed that an uninvited guest had arrived before him.

This is…

The qi was faint but unmistakably familiar. It would have been stranger if Baeksang *hadn't* recognized it.

Perhaps the guest waiting inside had wanted him to.

"You may all go."

The guards who were about to open the door stopped. The graying Captain of the Guards, who had served at Baeksang's side for more than thirty years, spoke up.

"My lord, even so…"

"That's enough. Guard the grounds."

After staring at Baeksang for a moment at his cold words, the captain scattered throughout the manor with his subordinates.

Baeksang glanced at them, then gripped the door handle firmly and pushed.

The door slid open.

Night had fallen outside, but his quarters were brightly lit. The residence was spacious, as befitted a Great Chieftain, yet furnished with almost nothing.

One person waited inside.

"You're late. Where have you been?"

Baeksang answered calmly.

"You already know, don't you, Palace Lord?"

A bitter smile touched the lips of his uninvited guest, the Beast Miao King.

Chapter 666

Baeksang's voice remained calm despite the Beast Miao King's sudden, uninvited arrival.

"You already know, don't you, Palace Lord?"

The Beast Miao King smiled bitterly.

Baeksang was right. A considerable number of tribal chieftains had turned against him, but he was still the master of the Nanman Beast Palace. Within the Inner Palace, at least, he knew Baeksang's every move.

"You spent quite a while in the underground prison. What did you and that boy have to talk about for so long?"

"…"

Baeksang faltered as he remembered his conversation with Jin Taekyung. Only for a moment.

"I told him he would be executed at noon two days from now, in front of everyone."

"And?"

"I told him no one could stop it."

The remark was aimed squarely at him. The Beast Miao King's eyes darkened.

"Do you truly believe that?"

"Of course."

"And if I refuse to let it happen?"

"The Palace Lord stands at the forefront, nothing more. The authority to decide Nanman's great affairs belongs solely to the Tribal Grand Council."

Baeksang spoke quietly, then went on.

"Have you forgotten the oath our ancestors made hundreds of years ago, when they gathered beneath a single banner on this land?"

"…!"

"The outcome will not change. Tomorrow, the final Tribal Grand Council will take up the execution of the Han Chinese Jin Taekyung."

The Beast Miao King regarded Baeksang with a grave expression. He knew the balance of power had already tipped. But if he had given up on Jin Taekyung, he would never have come here.

"Is that all?"

"Twenty tribal chieftains, myself included, have already agreed. If you defy the will of the Tribal Grand Council and choose another course…"

"That is not what I'm asking."

The Beast Miao King cut off Baeksang's words and continued with a sigh.

“Did you tell Jin Taekyung about Hwi?”

“…!”

A crack appeared in Baeksang’s impassive expression. It had been true in the past, and it remained true now: after decades of wearing an iron mask, only the child he could no longer keep by his side could shake him.

The Beast Miao King knew that better than anyone.

“I haven’t planted anyone in the underground prison. I only suspected it. Seeing how shaken you were, so unlike yourself, confirmed it.”

“How…”

“How could I not know? We’ve spent our whole lives together.”

Baeksang fell silent. *We.* The word struck him with unexpected force. Once, it had come naturally to them both. Now it felt strange.

And yet…

Grind.

“That was when you and I stood on the same path, Palace Lord.”

The Beast Miao King shook his head.

“We still do. We have never once parted ways.”

“It’s too late.”

“It isn’t. We’re still sworn brothers, bound together in our hearts. Even now, we can put right what went wrong.”

“To me, those bonds belong to a distant past.”

“And you’ve been trapped in that past all this time, little brother.”

“…!”

“I remember that day too. How could I forget the day a child more upright and radiant than anyone vanished from this land?”

Baeksang clenched his teeth. The memory was painful even to summon.

Yet he knew something else, too. When the truth of that day had come to light, someone had been just as furious and grief-stricken as he was.

None of it had done any good.

“Neither of us could do anything. The evidence of their crimes was gone, and everything was buried beneath the peace that followed.”

Countless footprints left on a sandy shore vanished when the next wave rolled in.

But Baeksang remembered. He had etched the faces of those who turned away from his child in danger into his flesh and bones, and turned them over in his heart ever since.

He had believed they were all walking side by side across the vast sandy shore called the Central Plains. In truth, his people had been sent ahead simply because they were foreigners.

“I can’t forget any of it, and I can’t undo it. So why do you…!”

Baeksang stopped as his voice began to rise. Sorrow had settled over the Beast Miao King's face.

"Do you think I've forgotten? I'm a sorry excuse for a father who had no choice but to outlive his children."

More than fifty years ago, the Beast Miao King's children had been among the ten thousand warriors who went to the Central Plains. They never set foot on Nanman soil alive again.

"I still regret it. What if I hadn't become Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace? What if I hadn't gone to the battlefield? What if I'd at least refused when they asked to fight alongside their father?"

"…"

"You're right, little brother. We were powerless. We burned with anger and howled with grief, but there was nothing we could do. We had to return to Nanman. Everyone was too exhausted to turn away the peace that had finally come after ten years and begin another war."

The Beast Miao King let out a hollow laugh. At the time, Nanman had been only one power among the Outer Lands, and the gap between it and the Central Plains was vast.

Even against the Zhongnan Sect alone, Nanman had been at a disadvantage.

Venerable Wusang, the Sect Leader of the time, had earned the respect of many through his bearing as a Great Hero. When he died in the final battle at Great Snow Mountain, countless sects and martial artists came to Mount Zhongnan.

"I merely made a choice. Between the dead and the living, between revenge and the greater cause."

What followed was known to everyone.

The Beast Miao King led the survivors home to Nanman and faced a flood of accusations from those who had lost family.

"My life was filled with regrets. But I never regretted that choice—not even once. Because we united as one, grew stronger and more prosperous than before, and gained the power to hold the criminals of the past to account."

Baeksang's face hardened at this story he had never heard before. Yet as he looked at the Beast Miao King, something he could not understand stirred in his eyes.

"But you'll side with the Central Plains again."

"Yes," the Beast Miao King answered without hesitation. "I will."

"Why in the world…"

"Because burning down an entire forest over one diseased tree would be foolish."

"…!"

"We need to uproot what made the tree sick. If we set fire to the forest instead, those flames will reach us next."

The Beast Miao King went on with a sigh.

“Once it was the Demonic Cult. Now it’s Dark Heaven. We fought to protect the forest. This land is part of it too.”

Neither the people of the Central Plains nor the people of Nanman would acknowledge it, but the Beast Miao King knew. Though they lived far apart, they shared the forest called the world.

And…

“You know it too, Baeksang.”

The man who understood it best was his sworn younger brother, looking back at him now with wavering eyes.

“I know. I know that no matter what this foolish older brother says, none of it will reach your ears. You will say that it is an old affair you no longer even remember, and that the Baeksang of that time died a long time ago.”

The Beast Miao King’s children had been killed by the Demonic Cult, but Baeksang’s only child had been sacrificed because people he had believed were allies turned their backs on him.

His anger toward the Central Plains was bound to run deeper and wider.

But the Beast Miao King had watched Baeksang for a long time. He had already guessed.

“If you don’t stop now… you’ll regret it. You regretted the past, you regret the present, and you’ll regret what comes next.”

Baeksang wanted to tell him he would have no regrets.

For Hwi, the child who had been his whole world, he could do anything.

Let them call him a vengeance fiend while he lived. Let them call him a Fiend after he died. He would smile and walk this path all the same.

Then why…

Why? Why in the world?

Why would the thought he had repeated hundreds and thousands of times in his heart over the years refuse to pass through his lips at this very moment?

He had already gone too far to turn back. So why?

Why are you doing this, Baeksang?

As Baeksang put that question to his hollow heart and found no answer, the Beast Miao King’s quiet voice reached his ears.

“I could step down as Palace Lord.”

Baeksang’s pupils shook at the unexpected words. But the Beast Miao King continued in a calmer voice than ever.

“You heard me. If you want me to, I’ll give up the position right now.”

Baeksang struggled to make sense of it. If the position became vacant, one of the remaining Great Chieftains would be appointed the new Palace Lord through the Tribal Grand Council.

But with Heugung and Yohi both gone, the meaning of the Beast Miao King's offer was clear.

"You would make *me*, of all people, the new Palace Lord?"

"Yes. That's what I said."

"Palace Lord. Have you gone mad?"

"Of course not."

The thirty-two tribal chieftains held the real power in the Nanman Beast Palace, but the authority of the Palace Lord's title could not be ignored. To offer it now, of all times, was absurd.

"What in the world is this…"

Baeksang stared at him, unable to understand. Then he fell silent.

Something about the Beast Miao King's manner—so calm, so unlike him—had brought a realization.

No. Surely not.

The thought flashed through Baeksang's mind. At the same moment, the Beast Miao King slowly spoke.

"Half a shichen[2910]. Half a shichen[2911] is enough. Open the way for them."

Half a shichen[2912]. *Them.*

That was all Baeksang needed to turn suspicion into certainty. He asked, his voice seething, "Why? Why would you go this far?"

The Beast Miao King's answer came without the slightest tremor or hesitation.

"Because they came to help us. Just as we once did."

"…!"

"And I'll help you. As I always have."

It's too late for that.

Baeksang spat the words inwardly and moved to summon the Captain of the Guards waiting outside.

Or tried to.

For some reason, he could neither take a step nor part his lips.

Baeksang closed his eyes. A voice he should have let go long ago still echoed in his ears.

How much more blood do you intend to spill, Baeksang?

[2910] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[2911] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.
[2912] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

The figures moved through the darkness in silence, keeping out of sight.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

They shot in the same direction, so fast that the wind split around them and leaves trembled in their wake.

By the time anyone noticed, it was already too late.

Swish. Thud.

A body stiffened and fell. One of the figures caught the torch from his hand and moved his lips.

“Open the underground prison.”

Fwoosh.

The wavering torchlight revealed Yayul Mok’s face.

Chapter 667

Infiltration. Assault. Finish.

The sequence of events could only be described as a Quick Attack. It lasted no more than a few moments, and the twenty warriors guarding the area around the underground prison collapsed helplessly before the unexpected ambush.

“I-intrud—!”

Sssht—thud!

The urgent voice that burst from someone’s lips died out before it could become a shout.

Moving like a streak of light, Yayul Mok struck the Bai warrior’s Mute Acupoint, then his Dizziness Acupoint. He caught the man as he collapsed and lowered him quietly to the ground.

Sss.

That had been close. A moment later, and the whole operation might have gone wrong.

“Whew.”

Yayul Mok let out the breath he had been holding and swept his gaze around the area.

Some twenty figures dressed in black, each wearing a different mask, watched every direction as they hid the subdued warriors in the grass.

—Report.

—All of them subdued.

The answer came through Sound Transmission from a man in a monkey mask.

The fact that he and six of the other men in black were the Seven Miao Tigers, the most outstanding warriors among the Miao people, was a secret known only to them and the Beast Miao King.

—One seemed to be missing, but I counted again. The man you just subdued was the last of them, Young Palace Lord. He probably stepped away to relieve himself.

—Any casualties on our side?

—None.

—Good. We nearly ruined everything before we even began.

—That would have been a problem.

Given what they were doing, *a problem* was putting it mildly.

On the surface, Jin Taekyung was a criminal imprisoned for an unforgivable offense. If word got out that Yayul Mok had tried to free him, even his position as Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace would not protect him.

But we have to do it.

Yayul Mok wiped the cold sweat from his forehead.

Young though he was, he understood how bold and dangerous this was. He also believed it was right.

Jin Taekyung is our ally. He came to help us. He even saved our warriors when they were in danger on Ailao Mountain.

Like most people of Nanman, Yayul Mok had grown up with little love for the Han Chinese. That had remained true until he met Jin Taekyung and the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Thinking well of Jin Taekyung did not mean he trusted all Han Chinese. An individual was an individual; a group was a group.

But he knew what was right and wrong here.

Just as his father, the Beast Miao King, did. The man he respected more than anyone.

—Do you have the keys to the underground prison?

—Of course.

The man in the monkey mask nodded and handed over the bundle of keys in his hand.

Opening the prison required five keys to be inserted in precisely the right order to activate the mechanism. They already knew how.

Click. Rumble.

The massive iron door began to move. As soon as the stairs leading underground came into view, everyone—including Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers—turned their clothes inside out.

Sssht. Flutter.

The wind stirred the torchlight across their white garments. In an instant, they looked like Bai warriors. They took up positions around the prison as though nothing had happened.

They would hold the post until the next shift arrived, half an hour from now.

We can only hope nothing happens before then.

They had mapped out the routes and guard positions beforehand, but no one could know how the operation would unfold.

Yayul Mok descended with the Seven Miao Tigers, his white clothes feeling especially strange today.

Jin Taekyung is on the fourth floor.

He knew where the cell was. He also knew wardens and guards were posted inside the prison.

They muffled even their footsteps as they went. Before long, faint voices reached them from somewhere ahead.

“Damn it. You didn’t cheat, did you?”

“Don’t be ridiculous. Just admit you lost.”

"Shit. I can't make sense of it. Five games in a row? I've lost two nyang[2913] already."

Wardens often gambled to pass the time. Their carelessness was a welcome sight to the intruders.

"Damn it. Turn your hand over."

"Oh, give it a rest. Stop whining and keep your voice down. The higher-ups are already on edge over that Han Chinese bastard. If they catch us slacking off…"

Sssht—thud!

The voices in the dimness cut off.

The Seven Miao Tigers were among the finest warriors of the Miao people—Peak masters whose skill was recognized even in the Central Plains. The wardens never sensed them approaching. In an instant, their pressure points had been struck, their keys taken, and they themselves locked in an empty cell.

—Gisan. Dogok. Stay here.

—As you command.

—Not even an ant will get past us.

Leaving the post empty would invite suspicion.

Yayul Mok left two of the Seven Miao Tigers behind and increased his pace. Faster than an ordinary walk, but not so fast as to invite suspicion.

Step. Step.

Six figures made their way through the underground prison's maze of corridors.

But things did not go as Yayul Mok had hoped.

"Hmm? Who are those men?"

Security on the fourth floor, where Jin Taekyung was held, was far tighter than usual. Besides the wardens, plenty of warriors guarded the prison's interior.

"You there. Stop."

Yayul Mok stopped without protest. As he steadied his breathing, he counted the men blocking their path.

Twenty.

Five of them were Peak masters.

These were elite Bai warriors. Yayul Mok kept his voice calm as he answered.

He had already removed his mask, and the few torches did little to light the prison. The darkness would help hide his face.

"We're here on the Great Chieftain's orders."

"The Great Chieftain?"

The Bai warrior who appeared to be their captain deliberately furrowed his brow.

"He only just left. What does he want?"

[2913] Nyang was a traditional unit of money, historically tied to a weight of silver. Its value varied by time and place.

“Nothing urgent. He said to give the prisoner another Force-Sealing Pill, just in case.”

“Hmm. Did he?”

“He must be worried about an escape. I’ve only heard the rumors myself, but the man sounds like a monster.”

The Bai warrior gave a short laugh.

“So I’ve heard. Now he’s just waiting to die.”

“I think so too, but you never know what might happen.”

“True enough. You sound young. Unless you’re here to relieve us, get on with it. You’ve got seven or eight minutes.”

“We won’t be long.”

Yayul Mok shrugged and walked toward them, his head lowered slightly to keep his face out of view.

Then he noticed one warrior’s hand gripping his scabbard tight.

They’ve already figured it out—!

Shing! Slice!

A flash grazed his shoulder. A few drops of blood flew with a faint sting as Yayul Mok twisted aside, evading two swords.

A shout like a thunderclap shook the prison.

“Intruders! Intruders!”

Peeeeep!

A shrill whistle sounded with the cry. Hurried footsteps broke the silence as warriors rushed from their posts throughout the prison.

Sensing them converging, Yayul Mok bit down hard and shouted, “Attack!”

At once, brilliant sword light flashed behind him.

Sssshh-shing!

Blades met in the dim torchlight.

Clang! Clang-clang!

Slice!

“Gah!”

A dozen weapons clashed in an instant. Blood flew, and men screamed.

The two men left at the wardens’ post realized what was happening and joined the fight. Within moments, half of the twenty Bai warriors had fallen wounded.

But…

Peep! Peeeeep!

“Stop them, whatever it takes! They’re after Jin Taekyung!”

“There aren’t many of them! Capture them if you can!”

The security was far tighter than their information had suggested. For every man they brought down, five more appeared. Bring down five, and ten took their place.

Worse, Yayul Mok and his men had sworn not to kill their fellow Nanman people while rescuing Jin Taekyung. It was one obstacle piled on another.

Sssshh-shing!

“Keep pushing!”

Bai warriors charged from every direction, their blades honed to sharp edges.

Surrounded by more than fifty enemies in the blink of an eye, Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers gritted their teeth and fought back.

Clang-clang-clang!

Slice!

Their hopes were one thing. The reality was another.

The enemy kept coming, too many for their small party to overcome. Worse still, Peak masters were scattered among them, each attack dangerous in its own right.

Sssht—thunk!

“Ugh!”

Small wounds multiplied. The bleeding did not stop.

Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers had brought down plenty of Bai warriors, yet the enemy’s numbers kept growing. Guards from the other floors had joined the fight.

Damn it.

Cold sweat soaked Yayul Mok’s back.

He had known this would not be easy. But they had been discovered too soon, and the prison was far more heavily guarded than he had been told.

If they capture us here…

Everything would end in the worst possible way.

As the Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, Yayul Mok would not lose his life. But his father, the Beast Miao King, would lose his political standing, while Jin Taekyung and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members—the original targets of the rescue—would be executed.

And then war will begin.

Not the Great Faction War they had once fought against the Demonic Cult. A war against the Murim of the Central Plains.

If Jin Taekyung died, nothing could be undone. That was one of the greatest reasons the father and son were risking their lives to rescue him.

There’s no other choice.

Yayul Mok bit his lip until it bled. His lips moved.

—Wonhu. I’m counting on you.

The Sound Transmission was brief, but it was enough.

Wonhu, the middle-aged man in the monkey mask and eldest of the Seven Miao Tigers, sent his sword flashing out and shouted, “Open a path!”

There was only one way forward now: break through, regardless of the cost, and rescue Jin Taekyung.

It was why they had all come here despite the danger. Yayul Mok could see no other way out.

If Jin Taekyung gets out of this prison, he can resolve everything.

Yayul Mok felt the hard wooden case inside his robes.

What he had told the guards before the fight—that he had come to give Jin Taekyung a Force-Sealing Pill—had not been entirely false.

Only it was not a Force-Sealing Pill, but an antidote that would lift the seal on his internal energy.

Clang-clang-clang!

Thrust! Slice!

“Gah!”

With defeat looming, the narrow prison corridor was their one advantage.

Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers drove toward a single point, ignoring the attacks coming from all sides. At last, a dark corridor opened before them.

“Go! Hurry!”

Yayul Mok left his loyal guard’s urgent cry behind and gathered all his strength to launch himself forward.

Or he would have.

Sssshh-shing! Grab!

A hand reached out of the darkness and caught his shoulder.

“Where are you going? Got somewhere to be?”

“…!”

For a brief moment, Yayul Mok fell silent, oblivious to the battle raging around him. Then he spoke.

“…Why are you coming out of there?”

Chapter 668

Sometimes, things happen in life that you just can't explain.

Like right now.

"Where are you going? Got somewhere to be?"

"…!"

For a brief moment, time seemed to stop in the middle of its headlong rush.

The Seven Miao Tigers, who had been rampaging like beasts despite wounds all over their bodies; the Bai warriors, who now filled the underground prison's corridors; and Yayul Mok—all stood frozen like statues, staring blankly at the person who had emerged from beyond the thick darkness.

How?

It was the question on everyone's mind. *He* couldn't be here. He wasn't supposed to be here.

But while everyone inside the underground prison wore the expression of someone who had seen a ghost, only Yayul Mok, whose shoulder was caught in *his* powerful grip, realized that this unbelievable situation was real.

He had to ask.

"…Why are you coming out of there?"

Yayul Mok's eyes were vacant, his voice dazed. The answer he got was remarkably short.

"I just came out."

"…?"

"I was locked up in there, right? So that's where I came out of."

"…!"

What the fuck is he talking about?

Yayul Mok and everyone else were thinking the same thing.

So what the hell? We're asking how the bastard who was supposed to be locked in the underground prison crawled out.

He hadn't simply been locked in a cell, either. They'd heard he had iron balls weighing more than ten thousand geun[2914] hanging off him like jewelry, and that his internal energy had been sealed.

And the bars on every side of his cell had meteorite iron mixed into them. The prison had been built for that one monster alone.

So how?

It made no sense.

[2914] A Korean unit of weight. One geun is 600 g (1.32 lb); ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg (about 13,000 lb).

The Bai warriors instinctively suspected a traitor on the inside. Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers wondered if their information had been wrong. And *he* took a casual step forward.

Step.

His footfall broke the silence.

The man emerged from the dark corridor into the flickering torchlight. Jin Taekyung frowned.

“Ugh, that’s bright. Hey, you.”

At Jin Taekyung’s pointed finger, the Bai warrior holding his torch high asked with a vacant expression,

“Me?”

“Yeah, you.”

“Wh-why?”

“Why do you think, you clueless bastard? My eyes hurt. Put your arm down. What are you doing, giving a presentation? Crossing the street without your parents?”

“No, sir.”

The Bai warrior answered blankly, though he had no idea what Jin Taekyung meant. Somehow, answering felt like the thing to do. So did addressing him politely.

“Look at this bastard, still crossing on green. I’ll give you three seconds to lower your arm. If the light turns red before you do, you’re dead. Three.”

“Ah, I’m sorry.”

“To hell with sorry. Put your arm down. Two.”

“Yes, sir.”

Whoosh!

The Bai warrior hastily lowered his arm. The already faint torchlight dimmed further, and Jin Taekyung nodded in satisfaction.

“Hmm. Much better. Good job.”

“It was nothing…”

The Bai warrior felt an odd swell of pride at the praise. Then he stopped.

Huh?

Wait. This wasn’t right.

As realization struck, an unfamiliar sound whipped past his ear.

Thwack! Thud.

Sizzle.

He crumpled, and his torch fell into a puddle. The Bai captain who had struck his foolish subordinate across the jaw without hesitation growled.

“You idiot.”

His icy voice snapped the Bai warriors out of their daze. They had watched the whole exchange unfold as if it were the most natural thing in the world.

What the hell?

It was like waking from a deep sleep. All at once, they understood: impossible as it seemed, this was real, and the battle wasn't over.

And…

"Now he's even putting out the fire for us. How thoughtful."

They had to subdue the monster who had escaped his restraints.

The realization came like a bolt of lightning. The shout that followed was thunder.

"Attack!"

The shout, filled with powerful internal energy, shook the underground prison.

At the same time as he ordered the attack, the captain of the Bai warriors was the first to leap forward. He kicked off the wall and shot toward Jin Taekyung.

Tap-tap—whoosh!

He was fast enough to rival a Peak master from a major sect.

The Seven Miao Tigers recovered half a beat too late. They tried to intercept him, but weapons came at them from every direction.

Swish-swish-swish—clang!

Wonhu, the eldest of the Seven Miao Tigers, blocked the attacks and shouted, "Hurry! Give him the antidote—!"

Clang!

The clash cut off his cry. Seeing Yayul Mok reach hurriedly inside his robes, the Bai captain knew.

Just as I thought. Not yet.

Jin Taekyung.

He did not know how that young monster from the Central Plains had escaped the underground prison, but there was no doubt that the boy had not yet released the seal on his internal energy.

Then I can do this.

Even a Supreme Peak master was little more than an unusually capable ordinary man without his internal energy. The martial arts Jin Taekyung had learned and the principles he had mastered hadn't vanished, of course. But unarmed, he could hardly hope to face a swordsman who had reached the Peak realm long ago.

I'll capture him myself.

The prospect of earning a feat no one else could match, together with his certainty of victory, made the captain feel lighter than ever. The sword in his hand blazed with dazzling light.

Ssssss!

Sword Energy surged along the sharp blade. Yayul Mok glanced back instinctively, and the captain saw his eyes tremble.

This would be the sharpest, most powerful strike of his life. He was sure of it.

Now!

Ssshhhiiing!

The motion was flawless. A perfect draw.

Sword Energy burst from the blade, cutting through the darkness toward both men. The captain cried out in triumph.

“Got—!”

Slice!

His Sword Energy cut through empty air.

What?

The captain blinked.

They were gone. Nothing remained where his Sword Energy had passed—not Yayul Mok, not Jin Taekyung. Both had vanished like apparitions.

How?

The next moment, an answer came to the question he had asked only in his mind.

“Oh. You were just thinking *how*, weren’t you?”

“…!”

The voice came from behind him.

Goose bumps climbed the captain’s spine as he spun, his sword following through a motion ingrained by years of practice.

Whoosh!

Once again, his sword cut through the air.

No. It *almost* did.

Grgrgrk.

The tip trembled faintly. Another question surfaced in his suddenly empty mind.

What… is this?

The blade, brimming with Sword Energy, had stopped before an unarmed palm.

No. He hasn’t even blocked it with his hand.

Barely one chi[2915] separated the trembling blade from the palm. In that gap, an invisible force pushed his sword back.

Slowly, but powerfully.

Grgrgrk.

With eyes trembling as fiercely as his sword, the captain squeezed out his voice.

“S-Seizing an Object Through Empty Space?”

[2915] A traditional unit of length. One chi is 3.03 cm (1.19 in).

The carefully polished blade glinted in the darkness. Beyond it, white teeth showed in a slight grin.

“Seizing an Object Through Empty Space? Well, it’s similar.”

“H-how? Your internal energy was sealed—”

“I said *similar*. I didn’t say it was the same thing.”

What?

“Don’t try to understand. You couldn’t even if you tried.”

It was a cruel truth. Even if the captain devoted the rest of his life to martial arts, he would never reach the threshold of the Middle Dantian.

“Wh-what is this…?”

That was a realm the captain, who had devoted his entire life to martial arts, could not understand. Unfortunately, Jin Taekyung was not the sort of kind person who would patiently tutor a dunce.

“Get lost.”

“…!”

At the moment the captain’s wide eyes reflected Jin Taekyung’s fist, wrapped tightly in chains—

Bam!

Pain unlike anything he had ever known exploded through his abdomen and swept over his body.

“Guh-heok!”

It was a punch so powerful that Jin Taekyung had to have recovered his internal energy.

But the captain was only human—a little more capable than most. He had no hope of withstanding a blow driven by strength and speed far beyond human limits.

Whoosh!

He could feel his body hurtling backward, hear the air shriek around it. His consciousness faded beneath the pain.

That insane… monster.

That was his final thought.

The captain’s already unconscious body grazed past the Seven Miao Tigers, who were still fighting desperately, then crashed like a cannonball into the Bai warriors filling the underground prison’s corridor.

Boom! Crack!

“Argh!”

“Wh-what was that?”

The underground prison descended into chaos. The Bai warriors realized what had struck them and stared, openmouthed.

“C-Captain?”

“But how…?”

The murmurs died almost as quickly as they had begun. There was only one person here who could have defeated the captain—a high-ranking Bai warrior, a Peak master, and the strongest among them.

“J-Jin Taekyung.”

The name slipped from someone’s lips. Every eye turned in the same direction.

Splash. Clatter.

A man walked through a puddle of filthy water, the chains severed from his iron balls dangling from both hands.

“Yeah, that’s me. Someone call?”

In complete contrast to the dark atmosphere of the underground prison, the smile around Jin Taekyung’s lips was as bright as sunlight.

Like a predator spotting prey.

No. Like a Fiend.

“Anyone want the shit beaten out of them with a chain? Hands?”

“…!”

“…!”

The Bai warriors froze as a chill ran through them. But not all of them stayed frozen.

“Attack him!”

“We outnumber them! Push forward!”

Swish-swish-swish!

A dozen or so figures sprang off the walls and charged. They were squad captains, each a Peak master. Though none was as strong as their fallen captain, the Bai warriors felt their courage return.

Or almost did.

Whoooosh!

A chain hurtled toward the charging men with a heavy rush of air.

Bam-bam-bam-bam-bam!

The chain swept through the dozen or so squad captains charging forward, knocking them away all at once.

Boom! Crash-crash-crash!

The underground prison shook. Everyone swallowed as they watched a thick cloud of dust rise. Then a low voice reached them.

“Is it summer already? Why are there so many damn flies…”

“…!”

“…!”

“Anyway. Who’s next? Hands?”

No one stepped forward this time.

The Bai warriors stared at the man standing before them like the Grim Reaper, then retreated as though by agreement.

But…

Boom. Boom.

An ominous sound rose from the stairs behind them, snuffing out even the faintest hope of escape.

“Oh, right. Forgot to tell you.”

Jin Taekyung grinned and pointed toward the stairs.

“Something big’s coming.”

The next moment, the Bai warriors heard a chilling roar.

“Taishan. Hungryyyyyyyyy!”

It was the roar of a starving beast.

No—of Taishan.

Chapter 669

The time it takes to drink a cup of tea.

No, perhaps mere moments.

It took less than the time needed to drink a cup of tea to settle everything in the underground prison.

Taishan, half-crazed with hunger, blocked the stairs. I advanced at the front with Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers behind me, and the Bai warriors lost their will to fight.

That was fortunate for me.

We needed to escape the underground prison as quickly as possible, but I was also beginning to feel my limits. I still had not completely grasped the full utility of the Middle Dantian.

Breaking my restraints had already consumed an enormous amount of mental strength. After one brief fight on top of that, my stomach was churning and my chest had begun to hurt. Taishan's arrival was like getting an entire army as reinforcements.

"Gwooooooh!"

Hmm. Actually, he was closer to the Hulk.

And it wasn't just the presence of a Supreme Peak master that made the enemy surrender so quickly. Taishan's eerie muttering had a lot to do with it.

"%#!"

"Gasp!"

His eyes gleamed with hunger.

To the Bai warriors, the sight of Taishan approaching while spitting out incomprehensible words at machine-gun speed must have been terrifying. But I knew exactly what his incantation meant.

"Roast duck! Maechae Guyuk[2916]! Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork! Beijing Sauce Shredded Pork! Garlic Pork! Twice-Cooked Pork! Sweet and Sour Pork! Soy-Braised Beef! Dongpo Pork! Mapo Tofu!"

"…"

"Kung Pao Chicken! Stir-Fried Mushrooms and Vegetables! King-Size Dumplings! Beggar's Chicken! Sweet-and-Sour Carp! Aaaaaaah!"

Hmm.

Good thing they couldn't understand Han Chinese. Then again, a man slowly approaching while chanting food names like he was possessed might have been even scarier.

[2916] Maechae Guyuk is pork belly with preserved mustard greens; the Korean name shortens the Chinese dish name.

“Hungryyyyyyyyy!”

“Eek! Dark arts! That monster’s about to use dark arts!”

“I surrender! I surrender!”

That bastard was a Saiyan[2917], at least by Nanman standards.

Judging by their reactions, you’d think he’d shouted “Kamehameha!”[2918] instead of “I’m hungry!”

Whatever I thought of it, his cry of hunger worked. Even the few brave men who stepped forward despite it got smashed by Taishan, and that settled the matter.

“Don’t be afraid! Charge!”

“We can do this! Strike him!”

The men who came forward were skilled enough to be considered decent Supreme First Rate masters even in the Central Plains.

Their only problem was who they’d chosen to fight.

Thud! Craaack!

Crack-crack!

Taishan swung his log-thick arms and legs, sending bodies flying in every direction.

The Bai warriors swallowed hard and lowered their weapons. Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers stared at me in disbelief.

“What? What are you looking at?”

“No, it’s just… wasn’t your internal energy sealed?”

“Yeah. It was. I still can’t use it.”

“…Then how?”

“Mine’s a long story. That guy was born like that.”

The human body had limits. I’d surpassed them by an absurd margin thanks to the System, but Taishan was a naturally occurring monster. Even without internal energy, he could beat down a First Rate master as easily as a rat.

Was he exposed to gamma radiation as a kid or something?

A reasonable suspicion, but it didn’t matter right now.

I looked at the Bai warriors who had lost their will to fight and disarmed themselves, then muttered quietly.

“All right. Let’s deal with this lot first.”

The short version is that the Bai warriors who surrendered survived. More precisely, Yayul Mok spared them.

[2917] A Saiyan is a member of a warrior race in the Japanese manga and anime series *Dragon Ball*.

[2918] Kamehameha is the name of an energy-wave attack in *Dragon Ball*.

Thud. Slump.

A warrior struck by a Pressure-Point Strike lost consciousness and fell. The Seven Miao Tigers, whom I'd gotten to know a few days earlier on the way to Ailao Mountain, gathered the unconscious warriors in one place and locked them in the underground prison. Then we headed straight for the stairs to the surface.

Squelch.

"I told you before… you're going to regret this."

I said it as we walked. Yayul Mok understood what I meant and shook his head.

"No, I won't."

"Our faces are out in the open. Once they wake up, whose name do you think they'll give first?"

Yayul Mok was the Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace. That alone said enough. The Seven Miao Tigers were also well-known warriors who represented the Miao people. Their tribes might be different, but some of the prisoners had probably recognized them already.

"It's only a matter of time before this comes out. We should've silenced them."

"It doesn't matter."

"Like hell it doesn't. You said we weren't going to flee along this path, so why wouldn't it matter? If we remain here…"

"Our identities will be revealed. Our lives won't be in immediate danger, but we'll pay dearly for defying the Tribal Grand Council's decision."

"I hate to ask, but do you enjoy getting fucked over? Is being locked in the underground prison on your bucket list?"

"Bucki… I can hardly pronounce it. I don't know what that is, but I knew the risk when I did this."

Yayul Mok continued quietly.

"Our tribes are different, but we're all Nanman people. We've lived together on this land for a long time. If we kill our own people, we become monsters too."

His words brought someone to mind. A man who had become a monster for the sake of revenge.

Baeksang.

Maybe that was the difference between a human being and a monster: refusing to sacrifice lives for your own ends.

Even so, I spoke with a heavy heart.

"We should've killed them all."

"You do like killing. Are all Han Chinese like you?"

"You crazy bastard. Do you think I'm some kind of fiend? It's just…"

"That's enough. I already know."

"What?"

I turned to find Yayul Mok smiling silently.

“You’re worried about us. You feel guilty because we got ourselves into trouble trying to save you.”

“…”

“The Central Plains and Nanman have different languages, but we have a word for *friend* too. Perhaps that’s what you and I have become without realizing it. Unless I’m the only one who thinks so.”

“…!”

Damn it. I had no idea what to say.

While I stood there speechless, the seemingly endless stairs finally came to an end. The entrance to the underground prison was before us.

“Wonhu.”

At Yayul Mok’s call, the middle-aged man nodded and stepped forward. He looked like a monkey. He tried the keys on a large ring one after another, and the enormous iron door began to open with a heavy rumble.

Grooooan.

Faint moonlight slipped through the widening gap. Yayul Mok took two small wooden cases from inside his robes.

“An antidote to lift the seal on your internal energy. It’s made with a secret Bai technique, so I could only get two. Once your internal energy is restored, you should be able to lead the others out of Nanman.”

“The others?”

“I don’t know if it was because they’re old and injured, but security around them was remarkably lax. Uncle Baeksang isn’t usually so careless.”

As Yayul Mok spoke, I saw them beyond the fully opened door: two unconscious people lying across a White Tiger’s back.

“Lord! Namho!”

Seeing the familiar faces, Taishan hurriedly ran out of the underground prison. I stared at Yayul Mok with complicated emotions.

“You…”

“Go. We’ll buy you as much time as we can. They’ll discover what happened within half a shichen[2919] at most, but even that should help.”

I didn’t know what to say.

What would have happened without their help?

Taishan and I might have escaped the underground prison on our own, but we could never have gotten out of the Nanman Beast Palace this quickly. As long as Namho and Sama Pyo were being held somewhere in the Inner Palace, I was

[2919] A shichen is a traditional Chinese period of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

bound more tightly than I'd been by ten thousand geun[2920] of iron balls.

I might've been captured again trying to get them out.

But these people had given everything they had to help me, knowing the danger it put them in.

Thanks to them, I had a second chance to undo my bad move.

"...Thank you."

At the thanks I had not managed to offer until now, Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers—as well as the men disguised as Bai warriors outside the underground prison—smiled faintly and shook their heads.

"No need to thank us."

"That's right. We're only repaying a debt Nanman owes you."

"My hyung[2921] was on Ailao Mountain. Thanks to you, I'll get to see him again."

People whose faces and names I didn't know had helped me. One even called me his benefactor.

I looked at each of them, committing their faces to memory. Then I took the wooden cases from Yayul Mok and stepped into the faint moonlight.

Soft crunch.

The moment my foot landed on the damp earth—

Ding!

SYSTEM

Escape from the underground prison before the execution (Complete)
You have fulfilled the Quest success conditions!
You have successfully completed the Quest, Escape from Namshank[2922]!
Issuing the Quest completion Reward!
You obtained a massive amount of EXP!
Level Up!
Some injuries and Status Effects have been removed!

As the Quest notifications rang in my ears, a cool breeze that only I could feel swept through my body.

Whoooosh!

[2920] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

[2921] Hyung is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male friend.

[2922] "Namshank" echoes *The Shawshank Redemption*, a film about a prison escape.

My muscles, stiff for more than a full day, loosened. The fatigue that had built up as I forced out the still woefully insufficient power of the Middle Dantian faded. Finally, the force constricting my Lower Dantian melted away.

Hoo.

Heat from the Scorching Yang Qi mingled with my long exhale.

Yayul Mok and the Seven Miao Tigers widened their eyes, as if they had sensed something from my appearance.

Of course they're surprised. I haven't even taken the antidote yet.

But I had neither the time nor the intention to explain every little detail.

I tossed Taishan a pill from one of the wooden cases, telling him it was a snack, then fed the other to the unconscious Sama Pyo.

Fwoosh. Sssslip.

The Scorching Yang Qi melted the pill like water. As the liquid ran down Sama Pyo's throat, color returned to his slightly pale face.

He's in better shape than I expected, but he shouldn't push himself for a while.

Namho aside, losing Sama Pyo's full strength as a fighter was a serious disadvantage. But it didn't mean we couldn't escape.

If anything, we were in a better position than before I'd surrendered.

We've got everyone except the reconnaissance squad, and I've gained a little insight too.

Then Yayul Mok offered one more kindness I hadn't expected.

"Take him with you."

Grrrr.

A familiar growl.

The White Tiger, looking at its lifelong friend and master with sad eyes, held out its back toward me.

"Muyaho is called a spiritual creature even among Nanman's White Tigers. He's like a brother to me. I trust you'll take good care of him."

As if it understood Yayul Mok's low voice, the White Tiger licked my hand, then pressed its nose against me and sniffed.

Yayul Mok smiled faintly as he watched it, then pointed in one direction.

"Go. Run straight northeast from where we first met, and you'll find the reconnaissance squad."

That was when it happened.

Thud.

At the sound of a blow, Yayul Mok's body jerked. Wonhu caught him as he collapsed, then grinned at me.

"I trust you understand without us saying it."

"You people…"

“Please look after the Young Palace Lord.”

Chapter 670

It was a short time, and a long one.

Long enough for a moment to feel like seven days and nights. Long enough to walk through the past several decades, year by year, and watch the newborn who had cried in the arms of his mother, dead from childbirth, grow into a fine young man.

Baeksang's deliberation was short and long, long and short.

When his tightly closed lips finally parted, he already had his answer.

"You'll regret this."

The Beast Miao King asked calmly, "What will I regret? Coming to find you? Or rescuing Jin Taekyung and the other Han Chinese?"

"Everything that has happened until now."

"Like you, Baeksang?"

"It's different."

Baeksang's expression hardened.

"Unlike me, you still have a chance, Palace Lord. One last chance to undo your mistake."

"One last chance…"

"If you leave quietly now, I'll forget everything I saw and heard here. As though none of it happened."

"How can I cover the sky with the palm of my hand? I knew what I was risking when I told you to spare the men guarding the underground prison."

"If I order them to keep silent, they will. The Bai people are no less loyal to me than the Seven Miao Tigers are to you."

"Is that… the last kindness you can offer me as my sworn brother?"

Baeksang nodded without a word.

The Beast Miao King gave him a sorrowful smile.

"Then let me ask you one more time, on the strength of that last kindness. Half a shichen.[2923] Open a path for them, even if only for half a shichen.[2924]"

"Palace Lord!"

"Even if I could turn back, I wouldn't. That's the one difference between us, after a lifetime together."

"…!"

The corners of Baeksang's eyes trembled.

[2923] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[2924] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

More than anything, he wanted to tell the Beast Miao King he was wrong. That unlike him, Baeksang had seen only one path ahead and had had no choice but to walk it.

But his lips stayed shut. His hand had already found his sword hilt.

Click. Shing.

The cold scrape of metal cut through the brief silence. The Beast Miao King's gaze deepened as he looked at Baeksang, sword lowered at his side.

"So that's your choice?"

"I can't help it, Palace Lord. Right now… it's the best I can do."

"It's much better not to hear that awkward formal speech. It feels as though we've gone back to the old days."

"You know as well as I do, Palace Lord. We can never go back to those days."

"Do you think so?"

"Of course."

The Beast Miao King smiled faintly at his firm answer.

Baeksang had made his decision. He did not hesitate.

Tssssss!

Dazzling light flooded the space around them. A vast concentration of qi known as Sword Force descended toward its target.

Slice!

Three tigers ran like the wind, led by the snow-white White Tiger.

Wonhu, the eldest of the Seven Miao Tigers, watched their backs disappear into the darkness and muttered,

"Damn, they're fast."

That was the entirety of his impression.

Those who were leaving had left. Those who remained had stayed. He and the others had chosen to stay.

"Heh heh."

Wonhu laughed, feeling strangely relieved, and pulled a gourd from his robes.

Pop.

The scent of liquor spread the instant he pulled the stopper. The eyes of the nearby Miao warriors lit up.

"Oh-ho."

"That smells incredible. Did you brew it yourself, Big Brother?"

"Hell, did they round up nothing but a pack of fucking mutts? Why are all your noses so sharp?"

He grumbled, but his eyes were smiling. With a look of helpless resignation, Wonhu passed the gourd to the men crowding around him.

"There isn't much. Take turns and have a little each."

"I swear, not a drop will make it back to your mouth, Big Brother."

"Now this I can't pass up."

The Miao warriors roared with laughter and took turns tipping back the gourd.

Nanman people were famous for their love of liquor. With twenty grown men sharing it, their boast that they would leave nothing behind sounded entirely plausible.

But…

"Ahh, that's good. Your turn, Big Brother. I left you a few drops out of courtesy."

Wonhu took the gourd at last and let out a short laugh.

Slosh.

One light shake told him enough. It was not even half empty.

The men stood there shamelessly praising the liquor, and he couldn't help laughing again.

"Turns out you're not mutts. You're just a pack of blowhards."

"Hm? What's that supposed to mean?"

"Has senility caught up with you already? You're only in your fifties."

"Enough nonsense. Drink."

At their urging, Wonhu tipped the gourd—not toward his mouth, but toward the weed-covered ground.

Trickle.

"Don't begrudge a single drop. If we survive, we'll sit together and drink all night. If we fall here, we can get drunk after we're dead."

"…!"

"…!"

The men watched him with solemn faces. Then their mouths curled into smiles.

"Yeah. I like that."

"Big Brother knows what he's talking about."

"You've always been crazier about liquor than martial arts, haven't you?"

Wonhu laughed. So did the Seven Miao Tigers, who had spent their lives alongside him, and the Miao warriors who had volunteered for this dangerous mission.

Regrets? Not one.

Even if every one of them died here, their only hope would make it out of danger alive.

That was why Wonhu could laugh. He thought of the man who had always led from the front, who had sent even his only heir here to set an example.

I'll gladly accept punishment for disobeying your order… in the afterlife, my lord.

Neither the Beast Miao King nor Yayul Mok feared death. They never put their subordinates in front of them as shields, and they never backed away in terror.

The Beast Miao King loved the only child he had had late in life more than anything. But if he knew what Wonhu had done, he would scold him. No life was worth more than another.

That's enough of a reason to give mine.

Wonhu shook the now-empty gourd, trying to get out the last drops. He watched the liquor fall like the tears of an ant, smacked his lips, and suddenly spoke toward somewhere in the darkness that had settled all around them.

"Hey, got any liquor?"

A low voice answered.

"I thought you were on duty."

"We both know better. Go peel yourself a tiger's dick and eat it."

Wonhu grinned.

Their scheduled shift change was long past, and the waves of energy reaching him from the darkness were strong enough to raise goose bumps.

"So? Are you going to share or not?"

"I've heard there's a monkey among the Miao people who likes liquor. Catch."

Whoosh.

Wonhu snatched the object out of the air. The moment he saw the rough, familiar gourd, a groan escaped him.

"This…"

There was no mistaking it. His lord, the Beast Miao King, had made this gourd himself and always carried it.

"Recognize it?"

The voice reached his ears again. Wonhu slowly raised his head, and a man came into view.

His white robes were stained with blood and filth from unknown owners. His skin was so starkly white that *pallid* was the only word for it.

"…Baeksang."

Baeksang answered in a dry voice.

"How dare a mere warrior casually speak the name of the Great Chieftain?"

"What happened to my lord?"

"You'll find out soon enough."

Swish. Papapat!

Baeksang flicked his blood-soaked sleeve. In an instant, more than a hundred Bai warriors emerged from the darkness and surrounded them.

Damn it.

Wonhu cursed inwardly and drew the broad-bladed saber tucked into his waist.

He glanced up. Clouds covered the moon tonight, of all nights. It was a poor night to die, but the darkness was a blessing in one respect.

The fugitives would have the advantage if anyone gave chase.

Please be alive. Both of you.

There was only one thing left to do.

Wonhu—or rather, all of them—raised their weapons and charged toward the enemy without hesitation.

Their roar was too great for fear to find a place among them.

Whooooooosh!

Cold wind swept over me as the landscape raced past. No people. None of the houses with their unusual shapes. Only thickets.

We had left the Outer Palace behind.

But we're still in the Nanman Beast Palace's territory. We can't slow down.

We might have to run without stopping until we rescued the Fire Dragon Pavilion members in the reconnaissance squad. The Nanman Beast Palace's reach covered this entire unfamiliar land of forests, plains, jungles, and swamps.

"Sorry, but I need you to keep going a little longer."

Grrr.

Yayul Mok was right: the White Tiger really was a spiritual creature. It seemed to understand me even over the rushing wind. With a low growl, it picked up speed.

Papapapat!

Its master, tied to its back, was probably another reason it listened to me so well.

I watched Yayul Mok sway gently with each bound and sighed.

Yayul Mok.

We had made it out of the Outer Palace, but I hadn't woken him. More accurately, I hadn't been able to bring myself to try.

If he wakes up, he'll find some way to go back.

If he did, everything would be for nothing. Abandoning the one escape route they had risked their lives to open would mean nothing but pointless deaths.

Given his position, they probably wouldn't try to execute him on the spot the way they intended to execute me… but if he wanted to go back, I would stop him.

For Yayul Mok. For the Miao warriors fighting for him. And for the Fire Dragon Pavilion members.

They could call me selfish. They could curse me and point fingers, say I cared only about my own life.

But as fucked up as it was, this was the best choice I had.

Damn it.

I bit down hard on my lip.

Within a day at most—perhaps half a day—a net over heaven and earth would be cast across Nanman. We had to get as far away as we could and find the reconnaissance squad before then.

The two tribal chieftains leading the squad are effectively loyal to the Beast Miao King. We might be able to rescue the three of them without much of a fight.

That was the best outcome I could imagine.

With Dark Heaven's intervention and Baeksang's betrayal now certain, and with me having become the star of a massacre that had never been in the cards for me, no one could predict what variables might arise.

First, get every Fire Dragon Pavilion member out. After that…

My thoughts broke off.

Rustle.

The White Tiger stopped dead. It had been running at the front without a moment's hesitation, but now it would not take another step.

"What? What's wrong?"

Grrr.

"Your master said to keep going northwest, so…"

Grrrr. Sniff, sniff.

What?

It looked in two directions, one after the other. Then it buried its nose in my hand and sniffed, just as it had before we set out.

Wait. Could it be?

At that moment—

Ding!

As the Quest notification rang in my ears, I remembered the scent pouch I had found at Yohi's Western Yao Estate.

Chapter 671

The place where I currently found myself—the Murim—had neither the dazzling scientific civilization nor the mechanical engineering of the modern world. Nor did it have magic.

But extraordinary things were woven into this world—things no less remarkable than magic.

Murim people accumulated internal energy and wielded power beyond that of Hunters. There were countless martial arts unknown to the modern world, along with mysterious, bizarre spiritual creatures and elixirs.

And… tracking scent was one of those things.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A Sudden Quest, Yohi's Tracking Scent, has been generated!
Would you like to open the Quest window and check its contents?
Y / N

The System notification caught me off guard. Almost entranced, I nodded.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Yohi's Tracking Scent
A new path has appeared before you as you flee from pursuit. Now you must choose once again.
You cannot know what awaits at the end of either path. There will only be the consequences of your choice—and the responsibility that comes with it.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Choose a direction to travel (Incomplete)
Reward: Linked Quest
???
Failure: ???

Goddamn it. What is this now?

A holographic window filled the air before me. At the same time, a memory from barely a day ago flashed through my mind.

"Looks like they really went at it."

"By the time I received the report, everything was already over. All that remained at the Western Yao Estate was blood and corpses. And… those things."

I remembered everything from that day clearly. It was the only clue left behind by Heugung and Yohi, the two Great Chieftains who had vanished without a trace.

Heugung left a severed wrist, and Yohi…

That was right. She had left a scent pouch.

But I had only just arrived at the Western Yao Estate, and I'd focused on Heugung's wrist instead. The marks on the severed end might tell me something about his opponent's martial arts and how skilled they were.

Yohi's scent pouch didn't seem nearly as important.

It wasn't even intact. The silk had a long tear in it, and the scent seemed to have escaped, leaving the pouch almost odorless.

I hadn't known. With everything that happened afterward, none of us had time to give it another thought.

It was the most important clue at the Western Yao Estate: tracking scent Yohi had left so someone could find her.

The scent hadn't escaped. It was like that from the start.

As far as I knew, tracking scent was an unusual object made for following someone's trail, just as its name suggested.

It wasn't something you came across often, but that didn't mean no one used it. Among the orthodox faction, there were the Lower District Sect and the Beggars' Sect, for example.

And the fact that I had spent quite a lot of time with the Successor Beggar of the Beggars' Sect—a man from an organization of truly enormous scale—and exchanged all kinds of stories with him had been an unexpected stroke of luck.

"Tracking scent, huh? It works, but it's incredibly rare. The method of making it is a closely guarded secret, and only a handful of people in Murim can produce it."

"Like the Ten-Thousand-Li[2925] Tracking Scent?"

"The Ten-Thousand-Li[2926] Tracking Scent? Hm. I suppose even you've picked up a thing or two."

"About five of your teeth are going to fall out in a minute. Want me to pick those up for you, too?"

"Ah. Well…"

"Go on. Run your mouth some more."

[2925] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

[2926] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

“Ahem. The truth is, I’ve never seen the Ten-Thousand-Li[2927] Tracking Scent myself. Ten thousand li[2928] sounds impressive, but would any scent really last over a journey that long?”

“What? So it was a scam after all?”

“Not necessarily. The Ten-Thousand-Li[2929] Tracking Scent you’ve heard rumors about aside, Murim uses quite a few kinds of tracking scent. The finest is commonly called the Thousand-Li[2930] Tracking Scent.”

“The Thousand-Li[2931] Tracking Scent?”

“It has several distinguishing features. First, the manufacturing process is disgustingly difficult. Second, the manufacturing cost is disgustingly high. Third, acquiring the Thousand-Li[2932] Tracking Scent made that way requires a disgustingly large amount of gold.”

“No mistaking you for a fucking beggar. You can’t get through a sentence without working ‘filthy’ in somewhere.”

“However filthy I am, your character is… Sorry. That was out of line. Anyway, tracking scent of that quality is worth dozens of times its weight in gold. Of course, it works just as well as you’d expect.”

“For example?”

“Unlike the unverified Ten-Thousand-Li[2933] Tracking Scent, its scent really does last for about a thousand li[2934]. And it’s almost odorless—so faint that even some beasts with extraordinarily keen noses can’t detect it. Humans certainly can’t.”

“Then couldn’t you just put tracking scent on someone and call it a day?”

“The trade-off is that tracking scent lasts for seven days and nights at most. If the target burns their clothes or fully immerses themselves in water, for example, the duration will be shortened even if the scent doesn’t disappear entirely.”

“Even so, you’d have to know you’d been marked with tracking scent before you could try any of that. You said that even most beasts can’t smell it properly.”

“True. But spiritual creatures are different.”

“Ah.”

“So there are only two ways to follow a target marked with tracking scent. You need either someone trained in advanced tracking arts or a spiritual creature with a nose keen enough to smell it.”

Remembering that conversation with Gung Gibang, I had to admit he’d been right about all of it.

[2927] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2928] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2929] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2930] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2931] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2932] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2933] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).
[2934] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

Grrr. Sniff, sniff.

A damp nose pressed against my palm, twitching with every sniff. I looked down at the White Tiger licking my fingers. Its rough tongue stung a little.

"…Right. You're here."

A spiritual creature capable of smelling tracking scent. Just as Gung Gibang had said.

This White Tiger—Muyaho—was even a spiritual creature intelligent enough to understand and communicate with humans from a young age.

The intelligence of a spiritual creature, and senses sharper than any ordinary beast's.

Looking back, the nearly odorless scent pouch had probably contained Thousand-Li[2935] Tracking Scent: the finest kind, said to last seven days and nights as long as the target stayed within a thousand li[2936], barring unusual circumstances.

The two other tigers, standing there waiting blankly while Muyaho sniffed my hand, made the difference plain enough.

Grrr. Grrr.

Muyaho gave a low growl, as if asking me which way to go. His great snow-white head kept turning between two directions.

One was northwest, where the reconnaissance squad had gone.

The other—

…Southeast.

Crack.

I'd clenched my fist without realizing it. It trembled. Taishan watched me, blinking his huge eyes.

"Pavilion Master. What's wrong?"

It's nothing. Nothing's wrong, so let's just keep going.

My lips parted, but no words came out.

Fuck.

The curse I couldn't bring myself to say hung in my mouth.

There was no reason to hesitate. Our route was already set, and the beasts were faster than I'd expected. Even if the net over heaven and earth went up right after dawn, in my current condition I thought I could find a way out of Nanman.

So why was I hesitating?

What happens if I leave Nanman with them now? What comes after that?

I already knew the answer. Maybe I'd known since the moment I climbed onto the White Tiger's back.

Even if I come back… I'll be too late.

[2935] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

[2936] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

Shaking off our pursuers and breaking through Baeksang's net over heaven and earth would take days, even if we went as fast as we could. Add the journey back, and it would be seven days and nights.

Would the people who had set out to rescue us still be alive by then?

No. If this incident had even put the Beast Miao King in danger, would Dark Heaven have any reason to hesitate before carrying out its sinister scheme?

They'll die. Dozens. Hundreds. Maybe even thousands of people.

I blinked slowly. Eyes closed or open, the world was still dark. There was no sign of dawn.

Fuck. It was like this when I first got to boot camp.

The sudden thought made me let out a hollow laugh.

Thinking back, boot camp might have been the easiest time of all. Back then, I could fuck up as badly as I liked and still be forgiven. Things had changed.

I'd come close to death more times than I could count. I'd survived after leaving dying comrades behind. I'd shut myself in my room for days and bawled like an idiot, swearing I'd never lose my people again.

Then one day, I gained the System. When I came to my senses and looked around, I found myself with a great deal to be responsible for.

Everything happening in the world felt like it was my fault, and I pitied the innocent people losing their lives in the process.

Each time, I thought the same thing.

What if I'd been there?

Now all I could do was laugh at myself. Those thoughts felt like a sham—like I'd been playing dress-up, trying to look like a hero.

That was right.

I wasn't a heroic martial artist. I wasn't the hero of some superhero movie.

But today, the people who had watched me flee until the very end were true heroic martial artists—true heroes.

"No need to thank us."

Of course. Nanman was only repaying the debt it owed you.

"My hyung[2937] was on Ailao Mountain. Thanks to you, I'll get to see him again."

"Please look after the Young Palace Lord."

Dozens of faces brushed through the darkness. Some belonged to young men, others to graying middle-aged men.

How skilled were they? If I set my mind to it, I could bring every one of them down within moments.

That only made what they'd done more remarkable. They hadn't stayed to win. They'd stayed to die.

[2937] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for his older brother or a close older male.

Even if it was an egg striking a stone, they wouldn't retreat. They would hurl their bodies against the solid rock, even if they were ultimately smashed to pieces.

Maybe that's happening right now.

And I… had left them behind. I'd sensed what awaited them, yet I'd gone anyway, clinging to an empty promise that I would return.

Haa.

The air had been muggy a moment ago. Now a deep breath sent a white cloud from my mouth.

Nanman really was a fucking awful place. Just like my mood.

I stared silently at the holographic window. Then I spoke.

"Taishan."

"Hm?"

"From now on…"

At what I said next, Taishan's eyes widened.

The old man opened his eyes without warning.

How long had he been unconscious? His joints ached, and he was tied to the back of a huge beast that bounced beneath him without pause.

A tiger?

His gaze darted around. Namho realized Yayul Mok's plan had succeeded. Then he noticed something strange.

"…Why? Why isn't that bastard here?"

At the old man's voice, filled with confusion, Taishan turned his head.

"Namho. You awake?"

Namho didn't answer. A terrible feeling pressed against his chest.

"Where is he?"

"…Namho."

"Where is he? Where's Jin Taekyung, that bastard?"

The eastern sky was beginning to brighten, but Taishan's expression darkened.

Namho knew then that his fear hadn't been unfounded.

Chapter 672

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

The fierce wind rippled the White Tiger's snowy fur. Gripping Muyaho by the scruff of his neck, I watched the scenery race past.

Thick undergrowth filled the forest, and trees towered over it like giants. A snake hiding between moss-covered rocks glared at us with bright yellow eyes, while a leopard lying flat in the grass and searching for prey spotted the White Tiger and slowly began backing away.

Above it all, the sky was growing brighter.

Already?

I muttered to myself, then realized how much time had passed. We'd escaped the underground prison just after midnight. By my rough calculation, we'd been running nonstop for at least three shichen.[2938]

Grrr.

Perhaps that was why the breathing of the White Tiger carrying me—Muyaho—was much rougher than before, and fatigue could be felt in every step he took.

Can't blame him.

After all my time in Murim, I could say this with confidence: even a Peak Master who knew a movement technique would get varicose veins from running full speed through this godforsaken place for three shichen.[2939]

And Muyaho was enormous, even for a tiger. Crossing terrain so rugged that Kim Jeong-ho[2940] would have given up on mapmaking must have drained his stamina and worn down his muscles. On top of that, he had me to carry, and I was hardly small.

I wasn't a veterinarian, but I could tell what condition he was in with my eyes closed.

Only a spiritual creature like him could have lasted this long.

His physical abilities were exceptional, even by the standards of Nanman's renowned spiritual creatures. But if we kept going like this, he wouldn't have any strength left when it mattered.

I stroked his neck and whispered, "Let's stop and rest somewhere nearby."

—Grrr.

He understood and gave a small nod.

[2938] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.
[2939] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.
[2940] Kim Jeong-ho was a nineteenth-century Korean cartographer known for his detailed maps of Korea.

As luck would have it, I could hear running water not far away. We slowed down and soon found a small stream, along with a few animals that had come out early to drink.

Squeal?

Wild boars. Excellent.

I acted on the thought the moment it occurred to me.

Open Inventory. Summon.

I'd stuffed so many things into my Inventory while trying to survive that I was practically a walking armory. I pulled out a cheap iron spear I couldn't even remember storing and hurled it.

Two large boars dropped before they could make a sound.

Whoosh—thunk!

Squeeeeeal!

They must have been the piglets' parents. Watching the little ones flee, squealing as they ran, made my heart sink.

"Hoo."

—Grrr.

Muyaho nodded solemnly. I went on, looking mournful.

"The young ones have more tender meat. I should've caught them first."

—…Grr?

What, you little punk?

Ignoring the look he gave me, as if he couldn't believe I was human, I skinned the boars and skewered them on the spear.

Fwoosh. Crackle.

I used Scorching Yang Qi to start a campfire. As smoke curled upward and the meat began to cook, a short laugh escaped me.

There was no particular reason. Even I had to admit that what I was doing was absurd.

I've made an enemy of all Nanman, and here I am throwing a barbecue party.

I knew it was insane. Turning back along the southeastern route toward the heart of Nanman had been insane to begin with.

But every time I thought it through, I came to the same conclusion. Once I'd decided to follow Yohi's tracking scent, this was the best thing I could do. It was why I'd gone so far as to light a fire barely a hundred li[2941] from the Outer Palace.

The more attention I draw here, the better the others' chances of surviving.

[2941] This uses the Chinese li, approximately 500 m (0.311 mi); a hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi).

Before leaving, I'd urged Taishan again and again: run without looking back. Persuade the chieftains of the reconnaissance squad's tribes through Yayul Mok, then use the swift ships of the Water Dragon Stronghold to escape Nanman.

Unlike his usual self, Taishan had fallen silent for a long while. Then he'd spoken.

"Pavilion Master."

"What?"

"Taishan will go too. Taishan can't let Pavilion Master go alone."

Maybe it was because it had been dawn, or maybe because his words had been so unexpected. For that moment, at least, I think I had been rather sentimental too.

But moved as I was, I knew the truth: if even one of them came with me, neither group would be safe.

"Wait with the others. I'll be back soon."

"When? How many nights does Taishan have to wait?"

"Who knows? Ten nights or so?"

"Taishan doesn't like that. Ten nights is too long."

"Then five."

"Good. Promise?"

"Yeah. Promise."

And I'd left them with a promise I wasn't sure I could keep.

Five nights.

Could I make it back by then? No—could I make it back at all? I honestly didn't know.

The Logout function was still blocked, even after my escape from the underground prison. By now, countless Nanman people who had become my enemies were probably closing in from every direction.

Maybe…

Rustle.

Yes. Even now.

—Grrr.

Muyaho had been drooling over the browning meat, but now a low growl rose from his throat. I calmed him as he bristled at the intruders and sharpened my senses.

New information flowed in through my heightened five senses.

About fifty. I can't tell which tribe they're from yet, but they're all warriors… and they have no beasts with them. Did they leave the beasts behind so they wouldn't be spotted?

A truckload of beasts wouldn't have changed the outcome, but their absence did make things easier.

Once I had the lay of things, I slowly turned the spear over the fire.

Sizzle.

Beyond the appetizing sound of roasting meat, the intruders' hushed conversation reached my ears.

"That's him. He has the White Tiger Yayul Mok prized so much. It has to be."

"I'm not sure. I can only see his back from here. Shouldn't we turn around and ask for reinforcements?"

"Pathetic. Heaven has handed us an opportunity, and you want to give the glory to another tribe? We've come this far, and you're still talking like a coward?"

"B-but, hyung.[2942] Even if that man really is the Han Chinese we know about, how are we supposed to deal with a monster like him?"

"Even so, he's still just a human made of flesh and blood. Judging by the fact that he's cooking meat here dressed like a beggar, he must have been separated from the others and lost his mind. If we capture him here, we'll gain not only ten thousand gold, but our father might even become the new Great Chieftain."

Hm. So that's it.

I listened a moment longer, brushed off my backside, and stood. As I turned, I asked, "Really? Do I look that bad?"

"…!"

"…!"

Even from more than thirty zhang[2943] away, I could feel it: the trembling air and the many emotions wrapping around the enemies who had been approaching as stealthily as possible.

Shock. Astonishment. And…

"Attack!"

A rash decision born of stupidity and a vain thirst for glory.

They didn't know that my clothes were the only thing worse for wear. My body was in peak condition, and I was already hurtling toward them.

Whoooosh!

My body surged forward like a streak of light. Wind whipped up like a gale, and the thick grass burst apart.

Through the leaves shattering and scattering in every direction, I saw eyes filled with terror.

"What's everyone doing? Aren't you going to finish drawing your weapons?"

Despite my helpful advice, their hands froze around weapons that weren't even halfway out. The man in front of them was no different.

"Y-you…"

[2942] Hyung is a Korean term a male speaker uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[2943] A zhang is a traditional Chinese length of approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft); thirty zhang is about 91 m (300 ft).

I feel like I've seen this face somewhere.

It didn't matter right now.

"Why aren't you attacking?"

"W-what?"

"You said to attack. You came all the way here, and you're not going to?"

"Th-that's…"

"You won't? Then I will."

I tossed out a single, quiet word.

"Attack."

A huge shadow fell across the ground.

—Raaaaar!

With a roar, Muyaho leaped over my head and crashed down on the man.

Crack. Craaack!

Someone once said force and oppression were no way to communicate. If you wanted someone to open their mouth, you needed a gentle expression and a kind tone.

They weren't entirely wrong. Ordinary force and oppression wouldn't do it. You needed *fucking merciless* force and oppression.

And, as I was reminded yet again, I had a real talent for that.

"What's going on inside the Nanman Beast Palace?"

"You bastard! Just kill me!"

"Fine. Muyaho?"

Crunch!

"Gyaaaah!"

"Good boy. Now spit it out."

Ptooey.

"Urgh. Hic… hiiic."

"Why are you bawling so pathetically? You're a grown-ass man."

"Hic."

"That was your leg this time, but if you keep crying, I'll go for your balls next. Do you understand, you fucking bastard?"

"Ghk. Gnnng…!"

"Good. I'll ask again. What's going on inside the Nanman Beast Palace?"

The interrogation went quickly and smoothly. Of course, my preparations for it had been thorough.

I broke both arms of the men who came at me late, and the legs of those who tried to run away.

After crippling about twenty of them, I gave Muyaho his one-bite chance. They all became as docile as golden retrievers.

Is that about it?

They might have lied about some things, but what they'd told me had enough supporting detail to treat it as true for now. Besides, people tended to get honest when death was staring them in the face.

Especially when their balls were at stake.

Once the questioning was done, I glanced at the man Muyaho had pounced on first. His body was crushed, and he was barely breathing. When he caught me looking at him, he groaned.

So that's where I'd seen him.

He was the spitting image of his father, the tribal chieftain. Not that his father was particularly important to me. On the first day of the Tribal Grand Council and on the day of the tragedy at the Western Yao Estate, he'd been nothing more than a sycophant desperate to get behind Baeksang.

But that was also why I was letting him and the others live.

"Go back and tell them."

At my quiet words, the man's lips moved. His eyes were full of fear.

"T-tell them what?"

"That I'm here. That I'm watching you from somewhere nearby."

"…!"

"Remember everything you heard today. I will."

The man—and the other Nanman people nearby, who had been watching my every move with all their senses alert—shuddered.

They would probably remember this day for the rest of their lives. My expression, my tone, my voice, my actions—and the warning I'd given them during the interrogation, when I learned that the Miao warriors who'd attacked the underground prison the previous night were still alive.

If you touch them, I'll kill every one of you. Maybe not today, but tomorrow. Or next year. Perhaps at the very moment you think everything is over and finally let your guard down.

A threat frightened people when they believed it might come true. And in their eyes, I was more than capable of carrying mine out.

The inheritor of the Fire Gate Clan's legacy. The successor of Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King. An unprecedented monster who had shaken the entire world at only around twenty years of age.

That was enough.

Today I'd carved a fear into their bones that they would never forget. Now it would spread among the Nanman people on Baeksang's side.

Quickly. Farther and farther.

Until no tribe dared harm the Miao warriors.

With Baeksang still there, I couldn't guarantee their safety. But this was the best I could do for them right now.

"Leave at once. Unless you want to die here."

"…!"

"…!"

A little later, from the branch of a giant tree, I watched some fifty pale-faced figures leave the forest. They fled in a panic, as though they'd seen a ghost. I watched until the last of them was gone, then slowly drew up three jiazi[2944] of Scorching Yang Qi.

Fwoosh.

Flames gathered in both my hands.

It was time to light a beacon that would draw the net over heaven and earth toward me. A bright beacon with an entire forest for kindling.

Fwoosh. Whooom!

As I watched the horrifying heat and flames spread in every direction and devour the forest, a thought suddenly occurred to me.

Old Master would curse me out if he saw this.

I let out a quiet laugh and turned away from the blazing forest.

Ahead of me, Muyaho was already running energetically with a half-charred piece of wild boar meat clenched in his mouth.

[2944] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

Chapter 673

For the first time since the Great Faction War, the world had entered a period of upheaval.

It reached the Central Plains, the so-called center of the world, and distant Nanman, thousands of li[2945] away.

“Gasp, pant… Did everyone hear the news?”

“Catch your breath first. What happened this time?”

New rumors spread every day, and the people of Nanman no longer reacted with the shock they had at first.

Or rather, they thought nothing could surprise them anymore.

They had reason to think so. In the past month or so, they had endured one shock after another—more than every incident in Nanman since the end of the Great Faction War combined.

A Miao village massacred by Han Chinese.

The sudden attack of a Thousand-Year Spider from Ailao Mountain, which had been quiet for decades.

And a young Han Chinese man who had not only entered the Inner Palace—a first in the history of the Nanman Beast Palace—but had attended the Tribal Grand Council, where only thirty-two tribal chieftains were permitted to sit.

If it had ended there, perhaps things would have been bearable.

But just three days ago, more than a hundred Yao warriors had been brutally killed at the Western Yao Estate, and two Great Chieftains of immense symbolic importance had gone missing. After that, events began to move with the force of a torrent.

The culprit! The culprit behind the Western Yao Estate incident has been revealed! It was that young Han Chinese man! Jin Taekyung!

Wait. Have you forgotten that Jin Taekyung saved the warriors at Ailao Mountain the day before? Nothing’s been proven yet. We shouldn’t rush to judgment…

Too soon? Ever since those Han Chinese bastards came here, nothing but bad things have happened. There’s no reason to wait any longer!

He’s right!

Only reason could overcome anger, but the voices of those few people were helplessly buried beneath the shouts of many Nanman people whose reason had already gone numb.

Drag the Han Chinese into the street and tear them limb from limb!

Great Chieftain Baeksang! Make sure those bastards are punished!

[2945] A Chinese li is approximately 500 meters (0.311 miles); ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 miles).

The music and laughter that filled the streets whenever the Tribal Grand Council convened were gone.

Angry shouts rang out on every side, and two names came up again and again.

Jin Taekyung. And Baeksang.

Their standing differed as much as their origins, ages, and names. To the people of Nanman, that was only natural.

One was an outsider from the distant Central Plains—a criminal who had committed a tragedy that could never be forgiven. The other was the Great Chieftain who led the Bai people, the strongest tribe in this land after the Miao people.

The Nanman people still respected and loved their Palace Lord. His martial prowess was renowned throughout the world, and he was an unpretentious man. But after what had happened at the Western Yao Estate, their trust in him could not help but falter.

After all, it was none other than the Palace Lord, Yayul Cheok, who had brought the Han Chinese responsible for every recent misfortune into the Inner Palace.

Yet even those who had cheered for Great Chieftain Baeksang could not help but become flustered when they heard the new rumors that emerged at daybreak.

“W-What did you say?”

“Did I… Did I hear that wrong?”

Their pupils trembled, and their faces were filled with bewilderment.

Everyone who heard the news could only keep repeating the unbelievable story in their minds, wearing the same expression and the same look in their eyes.

The Palace Lord… tried to harm Great Chieftain Baeksang last night, failed, and then fled?

At first, they all thought it was a ridiculous false rumor. The Palace Lord they knew—the Great Chieftain of the Miao people, Yayul Cheok—was not that kind of person.

Before he was a fine Palace Lord, he was a good man, born in this land and more devoted to Nanman than anyone.

But the news that followed was enough to plunge the beliefs and questions of the Nanman people into an abyss.

“Baeksang is taking over as temporary Palace Lord? What does that mean?”

“I-I don’t know. But the Inner Palace put up a notice. It says just what we heard.”

“That’s absurd! How could it be true?”

“That’s not all. Apparently, the Palace Lord even mobilized the Young Palace Lord and dozens of elite warriors under his command to raid the underground prison and release the culprit, Jin Taekyung, along with the other Han Chinese.”

“…!”

“I can hardly believe it either, but the circumstances are remarkably clear. It’s an undeniable fact that the Palace Lord has been friendly toward the Han Chinese for a long time. And the whereabouts of Jin Taekyung, the Young Palace Lord, and the other Han Chinese are unknown. The Tribal Grand Council was convened last night, and they apparently declared this a betrayal against all of Nanman and issued a general mobilization order.”

“What? A general mobilization order?”

“That’s right. I heard it was decided along with the matter of the temporary Palace Lord. They must intend to hunt down and execute the rebels who have thrown Nanman into chaos. Naturally, the highest-priority targets are the Han Chinese Jin Taekyung and the Palace Lord. No—the former Palace Lord.”

“Former Palace Lord? What are you saying?”

“I don’t know. I’m still trying to make sense of it. But how would ordinary tribespeople like us know what really happened? All we can do is follow the Tribal Grand Council’s decision.”

The notice, bearing the unmistakable seal of the Inner Palace, spread through Nanman in no time. Its people split into three groups.

Those who believed the Beast Miao King had betrayed them. Those who refused to believe it.

And those who made no effort to question it or seek the truth, accepting the new reality as it was presented to them.

Amid the confusion, some fifty warriors returned through the West Gate to the Outer Palace. Every one of them was injured, some worse than others.

They trembled like aspens, terror etched into their faces. In their unsteady eyes lingered the image of the enormous fire they had seen from ten li[2946] away.

“Mon… monster…”

The voice that escaped someone’s lips sounded frozen despite the fierce sunlight pouring down overhead.

It was around noon.

Baeksang studied his reflection in a large mirror.

He was handsome and youthful, with a balanced build that belied his more than seventy years. His clothes were made of pure white fox fur. A stranger might have admired his bearing and taken him for the ruler of a kingdom.

But Baeksang’s gaze remained fixed on his own coldly hardened face.

Have I looked like this all along? For so many years?

[2946] A Chinese li is approximately 500 meters (0.311 miles); ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 miles).

He searched the past several decades and could not remember the last time he had laughed from the heart.

All he could do was draw out a memory long covered in dust and look at it once more.

Yes. That was the last time.

The chill in his eyes softened as a particular day came back to him.

They had won a hard-fought battle and been given a few precious days of rest.

The bold boy who had set out after his father, determined to defeat the Demonic Cult, had already grown into a handsome young man. And the girl who had been lively since childhood—and therefore always covered in scrapes and bruises—had grown into a beautiful woman.

The young man was Hwi. The woman was Hyang.[2947]

The two of them were as radiant and fragrant as their names. They were a pair of flowers that had bloomed amid a battlefield overflowing with blood and death. Though they called each other dog-and-monkey enemies despite having grown up together, they would sometimes walk together while avoiding the eyes of others.

They probably never knew that someone had been watching on the night they quietly left the others, who were drunk on victory and wine, to walk together along a hill under faint moonlight.

…You're here again?

…Why are you here again, hyung?[2948]

Why do you think? I'm keeping an eye on Hwi. That wolf might try something with my delicate, beautiful Hyang.

I have to ask—do you honestly believe that?

Of course I'm serious.

Then you know Little Tide Demon died in the battle three days ago.

Little Tide Demon? That bastard who could slap the Heavenly Demon across the face if lust were martial arts?

That's the one.

As a father with a daughter, I'd been meaning to deal with him myself someday. Good riddance. But why bring him up?

That bastard. Hyang killed him.

…

Hwi was fighting him and took a sword wound. Hyang came out of nowhere with a pair of axes—heaven knows where she found them—and split Little Tide Demon's head open.

…

[2947] Hwi (□) means "radiance," and Hyang (□) means "fragrance."

[2948] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

And apparently, that still didn't satisfy her. She crushed the dead bastard's balls, hurled every curse imaginable at him, and hacked his corpse to pieces. In Hwi's words, it looked like an imperial palace chef mincing meat with uncanny skill.

…You're lying. My Hyang would never do that.

Five people saw it besides Hwi. Three of them still can't speak from the shock.

Good. Tell them to keep their mouths shut. Otherwise, I might have to shut them myself… Oh. No.

You sound like a fiend… Gasp.

That day, the sworn brothers crouching far away in the darkness had unintentionally witnessed it.

The sight of the two children they cherished more dearly than their own lives slowly tilting their heads toward each other.

Turn your head. Quick!

Lower your voice, hyung! I've already turned!

Oh, heavens. What did I just see?

What else? Did you leave your eyes in Nanman? They were kissing—mmph. Mmph!

Baeksang, you conniving bastard. You put that wolf of a son up to this, didn't you? Do you want to be Palace Lord that badly?

Mmph! Hah! Me, Palace Lord? What kind of insane nonsense is that? Maybe after you or I die, but not now.

Ah, I see. You'll fulfill your dream through your son. Hyang could be the next Palace Lord, so you'll snatch her up and make her do nothing but housework. Is that it?

You're driving me mad.

Last chance. Admit it.

No! I said no!

Really? Swear to the heavens.

I swear to the heavens!

Fine. I believe you. Then prepare for them to hold their wedding this year.

How many times must I tell you I don't— What? What did you just say?

"Don't 'what' me. Just get ready to marry off those two love-struck youngsters."

…

Why are you just staring at me with that blank expression? You had already figured it out too. Unless you dislike it?

O-Of course I don't. You're right, I'd guessed. But… how do I put it? Huh.

"Then that settles it. No need for a long discussion. If the Western Front stabilizes before winter, let's have them marry and send them back to Nanman. And although the thought makes me feel strange… if they have a child, those two will give up their stubbornness and return willingly, won't they?"

A child. Ha… Haha. Has that much time passed already?

You're younger than I am. Stop acting like an old man. Promise me one thing.

What is it?

That girl Hyang. To me, she is more precious and pitiful than anyone. Because of her worthless father, she lost two older brothers and suffered terribly.

Hyung…

Damn it. What I mean is… Shit.

You can stop. I know what you mean. She's precious to you, and you want us to treat her that way.

…

You have nothing to worry about. Hwi will certainly do that. He'll grow old with her not merely as a woman, but as a companion—and sometimes as a friend.

I suppose I can trust Hwi.

And if you can't trust Hwi, trust Hyang.

What?

You know her temper. If Hwi disappoints her in the slightest, he'll end up like Little Tide Demon. I'd bet—!

Baeksang, you bastard! How dare you think of my Hyang as—!

That last shout had been a mistake.

Hwi and Hyang broke apart in the middle of their shy first kiss, and the two sworn brothers fled as fast as their legs could carry them.

Then, when they reached a quiet stream and were about to hurl a word at each other…

Yes. We laughed. Loud enough to shake the world.

Baeksang could no longer remember what had made them laugh so hard. It could not have been only the sight of each other's panic-stricken faces.

Perhaps they had been happy that the two children who had grown up together would be joined at last—and that they, sworn brothers who had spent their lives side by side, would finally become one family.

Hyang… If she hadn't gone like that. If only…

Everything might have been different.

But Baeksang knew that the thought was nothing more than a futile wish.

That winter, as they waited for a wedding all Nanman would have celebrated, the Western Front failed to stabilize. Ten thousand Demonic Cult troops swept in with the cold wind.

And then… the flower withered.

After Yayul Hyang—the woman who had been as beautiful as a flower and as strong as steel—withered on the battlefield, the light vanished from Baekhwi's face.

That must have been why, during the final battle at the Great Snow Mountain, he had cut down enemy after enemy as though possessed, stepping into ever greater danger.

In the years that followed, Baeksang sometimes wondered whether the boy had seen a single flower blooming somewhere in that narrow ravine.

Was that really what happened?

As always, there was no answer.

Baeksang looked at the mirror, now blurred before him.

No. The whole world looked that way.

Drip. Drip.

Not a cloud marked the clear sky. Yet raindrops fell from somewhere.

And then, in the next moment, someone's voice pierced Baeksang's ears.

"Oh my. Should I come back later?"

Baeksang turned slowly. In his bloodshot eyes, he saw a woman who had appeared like a ghost.

"…Southern Heaven Demon Empress."

At Baeksang's words, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled broadly. It was a smile as radiant as a flower and as wicked as a viper.

Chapter 674

Things happened in this world that defied common sense.

The woman reflected in Baeksang's bloodshot eyes at this very moment was one of them.

"…Southern Heaven Demon Empress."

His voice rang softly through the room. They were alone.

The woman—the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—smiled broadly.

"It's been a while, Great Chieftain Baeksang."

Her smile was impossibly beautiful—and more bewitching still. Baeksang's heart sank.

How?

Getting past the tight security was no great surprise. But he had reached the Supreme Peak realm, and he hadn't sensed her approach at all.

He had first learned of the Southern Heaven Demon Empress more than thirty years ago. Much had changed since the days when grief over his child's death had driven him half-mad. Yet the gulf between him and that demoness had not narrowed in the slightest. The realization weighed on him.

"…What brings you here?"

At his stiff question, she put on a sulky face.

"Why? Aren't you happy to see me?"

There was plenty of mischief in her voice, but Baeksang could not afford to lower his guard around her for an instant. He forced himself to remain calm.

"I simply didn't expect you to come in person. Normally, you would have sent a messenger or left me a secret message."

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress—or rather, Dark Heaven—had always done things that way. Baeksang was used to meeting black-clad figures whose names and faces were concealed, or finding messages they had left in unexpected places.

And he had never been able to refuse them.

"We agreed to meet again in four days. I would have come to you then. There was no need for you to make the trip."

He had followed that arrangement for decades. On the first day of every month, he exchanged missives with Dark Heaven between Insi[2949] and the hour of the Rabbit.[2950] Once every three months, he went to them alone, without telling anyone.

"Three days from now? Oh my, has it been that long already?"

[2949] Insi is a traditional time period from 3 to 5 a.m.

[2950] The hour of the Rabbit is a traditional time period from 5 to 7 a.m.

She widened her eyes as if she had completely forgotten. Baeksang felt his fist clench.

“You…”

“I’m joking. You’re getting worked up? That’s not like you. Our Great Chieftain has a surprisingly cute side.”

“…!”

“I came for a few reasons. So much has happened lately, and now that you’re finally the ruler of Nanman, I wanted to congratulate you in person. But…”

She covered her mouth and laughed.

“Who would have thought I’d see the cold, calculating Great Chieftain Baeksang in tears? Or should I say, the new Palace Lord?”

The corners of her mouth were lifted, but her gaze had sunk deep. Baeksang felt a chill in his heart before he spoke.

“It was nothing. The mirror brought back an old memory, that’s all.”

“Oh, because you thought of the son who looked exactly like you in the mirror?”

“…I’d rather leave that subject alone. What matters now is the future, not the past.”

“Well, if that’s what our Palace Lord wants. A good attitude.”

She smiled and went on.

“Though I am a little disappointed. I thought my gift had moved you to tears.”

“I’m grateful for the mirror,” Baeksang said stiffly. “I’ve been putting it to good use.”

“Never mind. I went to some trouble to find it as a gift for your appointment as Palace Lord, and now you’re thanking me only because I brought it up.”

She shot him a sidelong glance, then walked slowly to the window. From the Palace Lord’s Hall atop the highest hill in the Inner Palace, she could see countless pavilions and houses below.

“Wow. What a view. I suppose the Palace Lord’s residence ought to be special. You’ll get to see this every day now, won’t you?”

“I’m only the temporary Palace Lord.”

“Temporary… You don’t really believe that, do you?”

“…”

“My dear Palace Lord. Why pretend when you know perfectly well?”

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress gave the silent Baeksang a smile with her eyes before turning her gaze toward the view outside.

Sunlight streamed down. A cool breeze blew in from somewhere, and not a cloud marred the blue sky. The first fine day she had seen in some time lifted her spirits.

How could it not? Soon she could stain that clear sky with a darkness that would leave not a single ray of light.

Whoooosh.

Wind poured through the open window, setting her silky hair rippling. She closed her eyes and smiled. Moments later, she spoke.

“You know the great undertaking is entering its final stage, don’t you?”

“…!”

Her quiet voice made Baeksang’s eyelids tremble. Decades of memories flashed before him, along with one person’s face.

“Of course… I do.”

“Everything is going smoothly. Apart from a few minor problems.”

Baeksang could guess what she meant. The two names she spoke next confirmed it.

“The Beast Miao King. And Jin Taekyung.”

Resting her chin on one hand, she watched the Nanman warriors filing in below.

“Honestly, they’re more than minor problems. One is a Supreme Peak master powerful enough to stand among the Ten Kings. And the other is—yes—that Jin Taekyung.”

Baeksang watched her back. What he had dreaded was finally here. It was probably why she had shown herself after staying out of sight for so long.

“I’m sorry.”

“Sorry? For what?”

“How could I not be? It was clearly my mistake.”

“Hmm.”

She hummed softly, then said, “Yes. But it was our mistake too. I never expected the Beast Miao King to make a move like that. And…”

She glanced over her shoulder at Baeksang’s left arm. Beneath his robe of snow-white fox fur, the sleeve was empty now. It had not been the night before.

“I know our new Palace Lord did make an effort.”

The bleeding had stopped, but the pain from where Force had severed his arm would not fade so quickly. Baeksang bore a fresh throb of it as he answered.

“I couldn’t defeat him. I brought in every soldier waiting nearby, but he broke through the encirclement.”

“He may be the least of the Ten Kings, but he’s still one of them. Then again, perhaps what saved him was… that last bit of affection you still feel for your sworn brother.”

“That…”

“Wasn’t it? Can you deny it outright?”

Baeksang was silent for a moment.

“Perhaps. Yes, perhaps it was. At the very least, I might have been able to buy enough time to pursue him.”

"Do you understand what you're admitting?"

"Of course. But I can say one thing with certainty: it will never happen again."

She studied his dark eyes, then let out a light sigh.

"Phew. What a relief."

"What is?"

"That you told me the truth. If you'd refused to admit it, I was going to tear you limb from limb and kill you before long."

"…!"

"I truly am relieved. We haven't seen each other often, but I've grown rather fond of you, Palace Lord."

She gave him a shy smile, like a young girl.

"You know how, when you see a little ant fall into the water and struggle to stay alive, you find yourself rooting for it? Oh, I don't mean that *you're* an ant. I'm just not very good with words."

Baeksang felt the blood in his body turn cold. The fear pressing down on him swallowed even his shame and humiliation.

It reminded him how dangerous this woman truly was. To Dark Heaven, he was an easily controlled puppet, an animal on a leash—or something less.

But…

This is the path I chose.

That was the cold truth. Long ago, he had taken the hand the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—Dark Heaven—offered him. In return, he had received hope.

That hope had lifted him from the grief of losing his child and given him a reason to go on living. He could not bring this path to an end himself.

He had climbed onto a tiger's back. All he could do was ride it onward with all his strength.

Thud.

No one in Nanman would have believed the sight, but it was happening in the Palace Lord's Hall. The new Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, ruler of all that vast land, had dropped to one knee before a woman who seemed more beautiful than anything in the world.

"Please give me your orders, Demon Empress."

She looked down at him and smiled languidly in the sunlight from the window.

"This is why I like you."

She reached toward the open window, as though she meant to seize the Nanman warriors still pouring in under the new Palace Lord's general mobilization order—and the blue sky above them.

"Three days. Find the Beast Miao King and eliminate him within three days. As for Jin Taekyung…"

Or perhaps she meant to turn it all to darkness at a stroke.

"We'll deal with him."

With the great undertaking already nearing its end, she had no doubt: the path opened through Nanman would become a bridgehead into the Central Plains. And at the end of that path awaited the return of the omnipotent Lord of Heaven, ruler of all creation.

I'll stake Hyuk Mujin's balls on it.

That was probably a signal fire unlike any in Nanman's history. Maybe even Murim's.

Fwoosh. WHOOOM!

Two days had passed since I left the others in Taishan's care and headed south. I was setting my seventh mountain on fire.

Oh, the pasture too, of course.

"Wait. Is this the seventh or the eighth?"

Grrrr.

"Right. That's not important."

I ignored the White Tiger's annoyed look. Blood and soot had dirtied its once-white fur.

The blood wasn't its own. After we'd driven off pursuit squads half a dozen times, a little mess was unavoidable.

Soon, though, I wouldn't hear Muyaho complaining anymore. No—neither of us would have the attention to spare for anything like that.

Step.

The White Tiger planted a huge forepaw in the mud. It had been running like the wind until now, so when it stared into the black forest and let out a low cry, that could mean only one thing.

Yes.

"It's here."

I muttered while gazing at the mountain shrouded in darkness.

Chapter 675

I'd thought of this place from the beginning, but I still hadn't believed it would be here. Nanman was vast, and I was a Korean who didn't even know the geography of the Central Plains properly.

In fact, of all the martial artists in the world, there probably wasn't another hybrid quite like me.

An outsider in the Central Plains, for all intents and purposes. And undeniably an outsider in Nanman.

How was someone like me supposed to know exactly where we were headed, or where we would stop?

Besides, Muyaho was a spiritual creature that understood human speech, not one that could speak it.

So when the White Tiger's pace finally slowed, I realized where we were.

Looks like "no way" really is going to get someone killed. Fuck.

The mountain looked ominous even from a distance.

Ailao Mountain was just as it had been when I left it a few days ago: dark and chilly, with a smell of blood that seemed to drift from beyond the thick fog.

In short, it was the kind of place that made me feel fucking awful every time I came here.

As far as Ailao Mountain was concerned, they ought to invent a character for "dick" and write its name with that instead of the character for "mountain."

"…Is it really here?"

- *Grrr.*

"You know I'll chop your leg off if you're lying, right?"

- *Grrrr!*

"Ah. Okay."

Damn. Guess it really was.

I gently scratched between the White Tiger's brows to soothe its irritation and looked around.

A wolf howled now and then. Each time, mountain birds took flight with a flutter. Those were the only sounds I heard.

Yeah. At least as far as sound goes.

I checked the Quest window.

The linked Quest that had begun automatically when Muyaho and I split off from the group was short and simple for a Quest with a Grade as high as Supreme Peak.

SYSTEM

Quest
I Can See Your Tracking Scent
You chose to follow the tracking scent.
At the end of the road you are traveling now, may you find what you seek.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Find Yohi (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

Find Yohi, huh? Of course I had to succeed.

Honestly, though, it didn't matter to me whether I found Yohi or Heugung.

Quest or no Quest, I had to do this. Those two were among my best chances of thwarting the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and Baeksang's plans.

From what I've learned, no one knows where the Beast Miao King is, and the friendly forces inside the Nanman Beast Palace have effectively lost their power. With so little time left, the best move is to rescue the two Great Chieftains and take them to the Inner Palace.

Did you think I'd made Muyaho run like hell while I sat comfortably on its back enjoying the scenery? I'd thought this through on the way here.

After what happened at the Western Yao Estate, the Nanman Beast Palace considered me the greatest fucking bastard under heaven. If I charged in alone, all that awaited me were spears and blades.

But what if Heugung and Yohi—the very people who'd been abducted—came back alive with me?

That would turn the whole board around. No question.

Words carried different weight depending on who spoke them.

If Great Chieftains from the four tribes came forward to prove my innocence and reveal the truth behind the tragedy, everything happening in Nanman would take a new turn.

That was why I had to complete this Quest, one way or another. It was a brilliant move that could overturn the situation in a single stroke.

Of course…

"Can't make a brilliant move without a Go stone to play. And getting one won't be easy."

I muttered the words like a sigh. Then, sensing people closing in around me from every direction, I added, "So I think I'll catch a few of you instead of Go stones to start with… Who wants to die first?"

"…!"

As expected, no one answered. I launched myself forward without hesitation.

Whoosh. Fwoooosh!

Flamefire Path.

Flames rose with my footsteps and became a meteor's tail, cleaving the darkness.

There were more enemies here than I'd encountered at any point since I began following the tracking scent.

I could see roughly three hundred of them, and there were probably just as many —or more—lying in wait behind the dense grass.

But…

That's all?

I stood among the predators at the top of Murim's vast food chain. The enemies surrounding me were nothing more than a helpless flock of sheep.

I could subdue them without sinking my teeth into their necks.

Whoosh, fwoooosh!

I shot forward amid flames that devoured the darkness. Screams erupted from the enemies who realized what was happening half a beat too late.

"H-He's spotted us!"

"Stop him! He's com—!"

Kwaaaang!

The shout vanished beneath a thunderous blast.

The ground overturned, and enormous trees tore free by their roots. Dozens of enemies flew in every direction at once, as if they'd agreed to do it together.

"Guh!"

"Aaargh!"

Their tightly packed formation had collapsed. Screams filled the gaps.

As I walked out, brushing dirt from my shoulder, someone shouted, "Put the beasts in front! Attack him from the rear!"

"Oh, you animal-abusing bastard."

That aside, it wasn't a bad choice.

Nanman's way of fighting with beasts had earned its reputation. It was one reason Nanman warriors, despite being individually less skilled than martial artists from the Central Plains, had distinguished themselves in the Great Faction War.

Of course, that only worked when the situation called for it.

Grrrrrrr!

The moment a creature far larger than an ordinary brown bear charged at me with a roar—

Shh-shh-shhik!

A pale blur accompanied by a sharp whistle of displaced air flashed past my side and struck the alpha brown bear in the mouth.

Crack! Crunch!

Drops of blood scattered through the air, and the bear toppled forward.

With a single kitty-paw punch, Muyaho had subdued a beast that might have ranked among the three strongest here. Its eyes gleamed.

Whooosh!

I couldn't see it, but I could feel it: a chill spreading in every direction.

This is…

Fear.

The White Tiger had been born beyond the bounds of an ordinary beast. As its overwhelming presence bore down on the area, the beasts' growls vanished, and their bristling tails drooped toward the ground.

Another strange gleam passed through Muyaho's moonlit blue-white eyes.

- *GRAAAAAAWR!*

The explosive roar made the air tremble.

The wind surged. Grass and flowers bent low. Pupils dilating, the beasts huddled down and backed away.

And they weren't the only ones affected.

"Gasp."

"M-My body…"

Muyaho's aura fell short of the Water God Dragon's, or that of some of the monsters I'd encountered. But it was enough to freeze some of the less accomplished martial artists among our enemies.

Which meant, of course, that others could still move.

"You idiots! What are you doing?!"

I heard panic and fury in the shout.

I spotted a middle-aged man wearing a leopard hide well behind the others and shot toward him like a spear.

Shaaak! Crack!

"Aaargh!"

"M-Monster!"

That was right. Here and now, I was the only monster.

Someone they couldn't stop. Someone they'd imagined in their heads but never once thought they would have to face as an enemy.

Even if every person here stood in my way, I had the strength to keep going.

“Protect the Chieftain!”

“Stop him by any means necessary—guh!”

I tapped an opponent’s chest with my palm.

Scorching Yang Qi seeped into his body and disrupted the flow of his qi. Blood burst from his mouth like a fountain, and he crumpled.

“You bastard! How dare—!”

Whoosh! Tap.

Was the man I’d just taken down a friend of his?

He had plenty of momentum, but not enough skill.

I caught his sword between two fingers, putting Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade into practice, then shrugged at the face beyond its trembling blade.

“He’s not dead. He’ll spend about a month in bed shitting blood, though.”

“…!”

“Since you’re at it, you can shit beside him.”

Boom!

His body shot backward, sweeping more than a dozen people along with it.

I walked down the path that had opened before me and spread both hands. The fire dragon coiled in my lower dantian surged through my acupoints and settled in my hands.

Whoosh. Ssssss.

Terrible heat spread in every direction.

Water evaporated from the mud before my feet could touch it. Blue-white flames shone in the eyes of the elite warriors about to charge me.

“W-Wait…!”

I answered with both palms.

Like the former Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan who had once destroyed the Five Poisons Sect, I unleashed Flame Divine Palm in every direction.

Kwaaaang!

Rumble!

Flames shot through the air, swept over the undergrowth, and set the densely packed trees ablaze.

Beneath that enormous blaze, hundreds of enemies fled screaming through the darkness.

Among them, thankfully, was a middle-aged man in a leopard hide flashy enough to recognize at a glance.

“Move! Get out of my way!”

From the way he was running, he clearly wanted to live.

But no matter how hard he and his guards tried to get out of here, there was a reason the word *impossible* existed.

"Yeah. I'm afraid I can't get out of your way."

"J-Jin Taekyung!"

"They called you a tribal chieftain, but I wasn't sure at first. I definitely saw you at the Tribal Grand Council, though. So, how've you been?"

Shaaak!

This was why people called sword-carrying bastards ill-mannered. I greeted him warmly, and the first thing he did was swing a weapon at me.

Whoosh, crack!

"Aaargh!"

I dodged the sword with ease and broke his wrist, drawing a scream of pain.

Then I fired Finger Qi at the five guards charging me. Muyaho appeared like the wind a moment later, and the beasts turned tail.

Whoosh. Rumble!

Flames and ash drifted overhead. Huge trees toppled one after another like dominoes. The tribal chieftain's face went deathly pale.

"P-Please, spare me…"

"You're a tribal chieftain. Of course I'll spare you—if you answer my questions properly."

"I-I'll tell you anything you want to know!"

The chieftain I'd captured was my favorite kind of enemy. He valued his own life enough to spill things I hadn't even asked about.

Some of it was useful, too.

"…A general mobilization order?"

The chieftain nodded frantically.

"G-Great Chieftain Baeksang has become temporary Palace Lord, and an army of nearly ten thousand is already stationed in the Inner Palace."

"Go on."

"The Miao people are under strict surveillance and couldn't answer the call, but all of Nanman is on the move, led by the three tribes under Baeksang."

Damn it.

I swallowed the curse.

With the Beast Miao King having fled, it had been inevitable that Baeksang would become the temporary Palace Lord.

But this wasn't a net over heaven and earth cast to catch me. It was a general mobilization order.

No way.

Dread seized me.

Perhaps Dark Heaven's plan was far bigger than any of us had imagined—and far closer to completion.

If I waste even a moment here…

I watched the flames spread rapidly across Ailao Mountain, then launched myself forward.

Into the darkness crouched over Ailao Mountain. Into the flames.

Chapter 676

The fire I'd started with Flame Divine Palm spread from the entrance to Ailao Mountain in the blink of an eye.

Fwoosh. Roooar!

If the Scorching Hell described in Buddhism existed, I imagined it would look something like this.

Ash drifted endlessly through the air, mixing with acrid smoke. A fire demon rolled like a wave, devouring everything in its path.

Crack. Rumble!

The earth shook as massive trees toppled one after another, and mountain birds took flight all at once.

It was the sort of sight that would have made Jeok Cheongang, honorary chairman of the Forest Protection Association, roll his eyes back in horror. Fortunately, there were no beasts in sight, so it looked like the Animal Protection Association wouldn't be getting involved too.

Wild animals must be quick on the uptake. Have they all run away already?

Not that it mattered now.

I didn't want to take the home and lives of some poor family of muntjacs, but stopping Dark Heaven's scheme and saving everyone else's lives mattered more.

If that sense of dread is right…

I had no time to hesitate.

Running at full speed, I spotted a wall of flame blocking the path a little over thirty yards ahead and reached into the air.

Open Inventory. Summon.

Not taking White Flame out when I surrendered at the Western Yao Estate had been the right choice. If they'd confiscated it, I wouldn't have had it when I needed it most.

Shing.

Cool metal filled my hand. Flames flickering all around me reflected off the spearhead, so white it looked almost transparent.

Now.

With the entire area already turning into a sea of fire, I didn't do something stupid like send out Scorching Yang Qi.

What I needed was power and speed—and a single clean, perfect motion.

Whoosh!

The spearhead slashed diagonally down. A violent gust burst from its tip with a short whistle and tore the flames apart.

Fwoosh! Boom!

The explosion opened a path.

I flattened myself against Muyaho's white fur and whispered into the ear of the tiger that had hesitated before the flames.

"Let's go."

• *Grrr.*

The White Tiger answered with a low growl and shot forward like a beam of light.

The flames rolled after us like waves, close on our heels, but even amid the chaos, Muyaho knew exactly where it was going.

Papat!

The scenery flashed past. Clouds hid the moon high overhead. As we raced on with the fire at our backs, something about the path struck me as familiar.

"Don't tell me…"

A thought flashed through my mind, and I fell silent.

No. Maybe there was no *don't tell me* about it. This path and the scenery around it should have been unfamiliar. If I recognized them, it could mean only one thing.

The Poisonblood Grounds.

After the Five Poisons Sect, which had once terrorized all of Nanman, was destroyed, Ailao Mountain became known as one of Nanman's forbidden lands.

And the Poisonblood Grounds lay in its deepest, most secluded reaches.

If my guess was right, that was exactly where we were headed. To what might be the most dangerous place in Nanman.

But there should be plenty of troops guarding it by now.

The Nanman Beast Palace wasn't some backwater sect full of riffraff.

When five Thousand-Year Spiders—venomous beasts so rare they were almost unheard of—appeared, and the Poisonblood Grounds emerged after going undiscovered for so long, the Palace had sent a sizable force to root out any surviving remnants of the Five Poisons Sect and whatever dangers remained.

Even if they were trying to hide right under the Palace's nose, they went in there?

I didn't have to wait long for an answer.

• *Grrrr…*

Muyaho gradually slowed. It bared its teeth at something I couldn't see, and I knew at once that something had happened. Then I caught the smell seeping through the acrid smoke.

Human blood.

I see. So that's how it is.

I looked toward the entrance to the Poisonblood Grounds. It gaped like the maw of a gigantic monster, full of the same unknown dangers I'd sensed on my first visit.

No. Perhaps it was worse now.

Well, if it were easy, it wouldn't be a Supreme Peak-grade Quest.

I'd started to think things were going more smoothly than expected. But like Baeksang—though for a very different reason—I'd come too far to turn back.

If I avoided the danger in front of me, something worse would come rushing up behind me. Just like the flames sweeping through the forest at my back.

Rustle.

I climbed down from Muyaho's back and gently scratched under its chin, where it liked it.

"Looks like this is where we part ways. Unlike last time, you don't have to come back for me."

- *Grrr?*

"Go back before it gets any later. You can break through the flames and escape. I know you can."

- *Grrrr…*

Muyaho gave a soft growl and gazed into my eyes.

I could see conflict and fear in the intelligent White Tiger's blue-white eyes. With instincts like its, it must have guessed already.

Getting in would be easy. Getting out would be hard.

It might never see Yayul Mok again.

Yet it couldn't turn away as easily as it had last time. I supposed we'd grown attached to each other along the way.

"I'm not going in there to die. Don't worry about me. Go on—your master's waiting."

I stroked the back of its neck. At last, Muyaho gave a slow nod and sprang forward.

- *GRAAAWR!*

Whoosh!

Not toward the hill the flames had yet to reach, but straight for the entrance to the Poisonblood Grounds.

"Hey! Hey, you idiot!"

I shouted in surprise, but it was already too late to catch it.

I froze at the unexpected turn of events. With a mighty roar, the White Tiger charged headlong into the pale Poison Mist—then staggered back out.

- *Krrk. Cough.*

"…Want a poison-warding pearl?"

Muyaho paused, avoided my eyes, and gave a furtive nod.

Muyaho adapted to the Poisonblood Grounds much faster than I'd expected.

As if biting down on the poison-warding pearl weren't enough, it gulped the thing down whole. With nimble reflexes, it dealt with the venomous beasts surging in from every direction and cleared a swamp so wide that even Peak masters who had learned a movement technique would have hesitated to cross it in a single leap.

But the deeper we went, the more cautious its movements and breathing became.

Whooosh…

Poison Mist filled the grounds, making it hard to see. Something brushed through the grass. Water dripped somewhere out of sight. Apart from those occasional sounds, everything was quiet enough to make my skin crawl.

It wasn't this bad even when I came here with the Beast Miao King last time.

I had sensed it from the moment I smelled blood at the entrance, but this was definitely not a good sign.

A thought crossed my mind. Perhaps… No, there was a good chance the Palace warriors sent here a few days ago were already dead.

If they are, that bastard probably did it.

A Supreme Peak master whose name, sobriquet, and face remained unknown. Someone who had drenched the Western Yao Estate in blood and abducted Heugung and Yohi in mere moments was more than capable of it.

It was also highly possible that it wasn't just one bastard, but *them*.

Dark Heaven.

Even what they'd revealed of their strength so far was terrifying. They had emerged in the wake of the Demonic Cult, and I'd personally faced the Blood Lord and the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Their martial prowess was such that even now, after growing rapidly through the System, relentless training, and countless life-or-death battles, I couldn't count on beating them.

I haven't fought the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, but I doubt she's any weaker.

No wonder I was tense, heading into enemy territory alone.

When I'd encountered the Blood Lord, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had been there. And when I'd come closer to death than ever before in my battle with the Western Heaven Demon Lord, Jeok Cheongang had helped me.

But if the Southern Heaven Demon Empress is here…

Would I live to see my companions and family again?

Drip.

A bead of cold sweat I hadn't noticed forming slid down the back of my neck.

Lick.

Something rough enough to sting swept over my skin.

The White Tiger had licked the back of my neck. Now it was pretending nothing had happened. I let out a quiet laugh.

"Telling me not to be nervous?"

• *Grrrr.*

It was such a small thing, but somehow it put me at ease.

I'd faced death more times than I could count. After coming this far, what was I doing breaking into a cold sweat? If I let myself tense up, I'd be too stiff to fight properly.

Yeah, fuck it. It's not like this is my first time.

I called to mind the no-brakes mentality essential to the successor of the Fire Gate Clan and the heir of the Fire King, then thrust a palm toward the Poison Mist.

Boom!

The sharp sound of displaced air shattered the silence.

Scorching Yang Qi was poison's natural enemy. The fierce heat of Flame Divine Palm surged forward, breaking the thick mist apart and staining the dark Poisonblood Grounds red.

Hssssss!

Strangely shaped venomous beasts scurried away from the light and heat.

The tangled, maze-like paths finally lay exposed. I glared into them, put internal energy behind my voice, and roared.

"Come out, you fucking bastards!"

• *GRAAAAAAWR!*

How had this happened?

Yohi came to her senses and blinked into darkness so deep she couldn't see an inch in front of her.

"Ah."

Her usually alluring voice was half-hoarse. Her body ached all over, perhaps from lying still for so long.

Then fragments of memory began to return.

"…!"

Her heart lurched. Her body, relaxed for a moment, went rigid as stone.

In Yohi's trembling eyes, memories she couldn't believe were flashing past.

Screams. Corpses. Blood.

And the face of the one person responsible for it all.

She was about to scream when a voice, carefully hushed, came from the darkness.

"Calm yourself, Yohi."

“Gasp…!”

“Don’t be frightened. It’s me.”

Yohi barely managed to swallow her scream and calm her pounding heart.

As her eyes adjusted to the dark, a familiar figure came into view.

“Heugung? Is it really you, big brother Heugung?”

“That’s right. Don’t you remember?”

It took her a moment to piece her memories back together. She recalled Heugung resisting *him* to the very end.

“I forgot for a moment. But why are you speaking so differently…?”

Heugung had been waiting not far away in the darkness for her to wake. He gave her a bitter smile.

“There were various circumstances. Circumstances I couldn’t easily tell even you.”

His tone was so courteous. Yohi was used to seeing Heugung grin foolishly and call her “little sister”; this side of him felt strange. But it wasn’t what mattered now.

“Where are we? Wh-where is that man?”

“I don’t know either. I woke up here.”

Iron chains bound her body, and her internal energy wouldn’t budge.

Yohi searched the darkness around her in despair. Then came a heavy noise, and faint light poured in.

Chapter 677

Click. Rumble.

The stone gate swung open, spilling light into the darkness.

Heugung and Yohi, whose eyes had grown accustomed to the darkness, instinctively shrank back and groaned. Then a voice bored into their ears.

“Oh-ho. Now that’s a sight worth seeing.”

“…!”

“…!”

“Of course. This is how the barbarians of Nanman ought to look.”

The voice slurred and swayed as though its owner were drunk. Both of them trembled.

Was it because they felt humiliated by the mockery and ridicule in his words?

No. It was because of fear. Because of terror.

That voice…

Yohi recognized it, and her blood seemed to turn cold.

How could she forget the voice of the Fiend who had appeared like a ghost, slaughtered her warriors, and left Heugung with one arm after a single move?

Her mind went blank. Beside her, Heugung whispered as quietly as he could.

“Remember this. You must never open your eyes—”

Boom!

A sharp blast of displaced air sounded, followed by a scream.

Yohi squeezed her eyes shut as he had told her. She could not see him, but it was easy enough to imagine Heugung coughing up dark-red blood from his internal injuries.

“Stop! Please, stop!”

“Cough, cough. Yohi, stay still—”

Boom! Thud.

Another blast of displaced air rang out, and Yohi could no longer endure it. She opened her eyes.

Heugung lay on the floor, his whole body bound. He had vomited what looked like a full doe[2951] of blood. The Fiend stood over him.

“You…”

“I heard you were a clever woman. Seems that was just a rumor.”

The Fiend revealed yellow teeth in a grin as Yohi’s voice slipped between her trembling lips.

[2951] A *doe* is a traditional Korean unit of volume, roughly 1.8 liters (about 0.48 US gal).

His white hair was nearly as disheveled as a bird's nest, and his eyes were narrow slits. He had hidden his face behind a mask in the Western Yao Estate, but there was no doubt that the old man before her was the same Fiend.

"Why didn't you listen to that fellow? If you hadn't seen this old man's face, you might have lived for another fifteen minutes."

"…!"

"Well, too late now. I'll just have to send you both to the afterlife together."

He shrugged and reached toward her. His arm was unnaturally long for such a small man.

His palm was covered in spots Yohi could not identify. As it drew closer, so did the smell of death.

Yohi knew this was the end. She was about to struggle when—

"That's enough, Black Hand."

The words came through the gap in the half-open stone gate. The old man called Black Hand withdrew his hand and sighed.

"Now I can't even have a little fun without watching myself."

Someone beyond the gate answered.

"Was that directed at me?"

The voice was as cold as eternal snow. Black Hand smacked his lips.

"Of course not. I was talking to myself. Just talking to myself."

"Stop acting like a reckless brat. You haven't forgotten the order given by Her Majesty the Demon Empress, have you?"

Black Hand's face twisted.

"Reckless? I never thought I'd hear that at my age."

"Then act your age. If you do anything rash with the great undertaking so close at hand, I will not forgive you."

"…"

"I'll take your silence as an answer."

Yohi had sensed no one outside the gate, nor could she sense anyone leaving. But when Black Hand muttered a moment later, she knew the speaker was gone.

"Damn old monster."

To Black Hand, it might have been a passing complaint. Yohi had to fight to keep her shock and fear off her face.

There's someone else.

She did not know who had spoken from beyond the gate. But their exchange had told her enough.

That person possesses enough seniority and martial prowess to make even the Fiend before me obey him.

And there was something more.

The Demon Empress. He definitely said the Demon Empress.

Two words that had appeared in the middle of their short conversation.

The Demon Empress.

Yohi knew whom he meant.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

One of Dark Heaven's core figures, said to be unnaturally beautiful and more dangerous still.

Everything concerning the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was treated as top-secret information. But Yohi was one of Nanman's four Great Chieftains, so she was an exception.

More importantly, she had a great tree named Baeksang whom she could trust and rely on.

> "Stand by my side, and I'll give you what you want."

He had said it when they first met, shortly after Yohi became a Great Chieftain. She had asked him:

> "What do you intend to give me?"

> "Vast wealth and influence. And the restoration of the Yao people."

> "Interesting. But I'll refuse."

> "Why?"

> "Even if I accept your offer, Great Chieftain Baeksang, I won't get as much as I want. I'm more ambitious than I look. And I'm not naive enough to make Palace Lord Yayul my enemy over a promise you might not keep."

> "You inherited the Western Yao Estate when you took the position of Great Chieftain. Do you have any trustworthy subordinates there?"

> "Of course. But why are you suddenly asking about that…?"

> “I thought I might send a belated gift to congratulate you. Five carts of gold should be enough to start with.”

> “…!”

> “Go home for now. If you wish to accept my offer, meet me here at this time tomorrow.”

Five carts of gold.

At first, Yohi had hardly believed him. She had never imagined a sum like that. Then she saw the gleaming piles of gold waiting for her, and doubt became impossible.

Baeksang kept his promises. If she stood by him, she might receive more than she had asked for.

Yohi spent a sleepless night and went straight to Baeksang the next day. She thought her judgment had been sound.

No. She had believed it was sound.

Until the Fiend came for her.

“Oh-ho. Look at this little bitch.”

As if his irritation had vanished, Black Hand gave her a hazy, drunken smile.

“Those eyes have gone so wide. You’re starting to understand, aren’t you?”

“I—I…”

“I’ve heard the gist of it. They said things went smoothly for us thanks to you. I’ll give Baeksang that much—for a barbarian, he handled his part rather well.”

Yohi’s pupils shook violently.

She could not believe the situation she was in: not only had she served as a pawn of Dark Heaven, she was now in danger of dying.

“That can’t be. It can’t. I didn’t know…”

“Didn’t know? Or pretended not to?”

“…!”

“I don’t even need to ask. After all, you followed that bastard Baeksang for more than ten years. A woman who had risen to become a Great Chieftain would naturally have had her doubts.”

Yohi could only stare blankly at Black Hand as he chuckled.

Everything he said was true.

It had started small. At the annual Tribal Grand Council, she supported Baeksang’s proposals. She followed a few minor instructions from him. In return, gold and influence came pouring in.

As the years passed, her doubts deepened. A few months ago, she began hearing the name Dark Heaven more and more often, and unease took hold.

But she did nothing. She pushed down her suspicions and refused to look at them.

She had gained too much to expose everything and try to put it right.

The Yao people looked up to the woman who had restored their weakening tribe. Chieftains who had once treated her like a little girl now bowed their heads first.

Even the mighty Beast Miao King and Baeksang would eventually return to the earth as a handful of soil. When that time came, she might even be able to reach for the vacant throne.

She would rise to the position of Palace Lord as a woman and rewrite the history of the Nanman Beast Palace.

That was the ambition Yohi had dwelt on every night. Now it was collapsing around her.

“Even so, you should be grateful to this old man. If the previous Great Chieftain of the Yao people hadn’t died suddenly, how could a stupid woman like you have lived in luxury until now?”

“Th-that can’t mean…”

“He was troublesome. His martial arts were pathetic, but he noticed things. A plague happened to strike the Yao people at just the right time, so he was easy to deal with.”

Black Hand grinned.

“Strange, isn’t it? The Great Chieftain was old, so his death was one thing. But then his three sons, the ones meant to succeed him, died too. The position passed all the way down to a daughter born to him by a concubine in his old age.”

“…!”

“Baeksang’s expression back then was truly something to see. He dragged things out to the bitter end, insisting he would somehow persuade the old man… Still, perhaps the bastard had a strong survival instinct, because he never came charging in. What a shame.”

Yohi stared at him, hollow-eyed. She thought nothing could surprise her now. She thought she had no strength left for it.

She was wrong.

“You did rather well for a woman, though. Setting out a tracking scent with your life at stake—that caution must come from your old father.”

Tracking scent.

At the three words that slipped from Black Hand’s dark lips, Yohi’s delicate body suddenly went rigid.

Black Hand saw the last of her hope break, and his delight spilled over.

“What? Did you think this old man wouldn’t know?”

He chuckled at the despair in her trembling eyes. He had seen it countless times, but the thrill of such moments had never faded.

“Oh, you poor, green little girl. You foolish child.”

A palm mottled with black spots, true to his name, stroked her pale cheek.

“You’re truly beautiful. Beautiful enough for Her Majesty the Demon Empress to covet.”

He opened his mouth like a predator over its prey. The stench from his teeth was foul; every one of them was rotten or grotesquely twisted.

“I’d like to kill you both with one palm strike, but… I’ll restrain myself this time. I have something to do first.”

He left Yohi frozen like an insect caught in a web and stood. After a glance at Heugung, who lay unconscious on the floor, he approached the stone gate.

Then—

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A tremendous crash shook the area. From far away came a shout.

—Come out, you fucking bastards!

GRAAAAAWR!

It was time to welcome the guest who had come such a long way.

My method of calling out enemies was simple.

I broke things, wrecked things, and smashed them to pieces.

Poison Mist? Venomous beasts? Enemies hiding somewhere, waiting for their chance?

I didn’t care. I rampaged like an eight-ton[2952] truck with a broken steering wheel, smashing everything in the Poisonblood Grounds.

They’d have no choice but to come out.

Before long, it worked.

“What a vigorous young man.”

“I expected the Beast Miao King if someone came looking for us… So you’re Jin Taekyung?”

I followed the voices and slowly turned around.

A short, squat old man swaying as though he were drugged, and a tall old man radiating such cold that I wondered if his hometown was King Sejong Station in Antarctica.

They could hardly have looked less alike. But they had two things in common.

First, they were both Supreme Peak masters.

[2952] Eight metric tons is 8,000 kg (about 17,600 lb).

Second, both were giving off enough killing intent to make it clear they had no intention of letting me leave alive.

I considered the two of them for a moment, then spoke sternly.

“One of you step aside. By the customs of the martial world, I’ll take you on one at a time.”

The answer came immediately.

Whoosh—KWA-BOOM!

Yeah, fuck. I knew that wouldn’t work.

Chapter 678

It was a relief that the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was nowhere in sight. But there were two Supreme Peak masters here.

Damn it. I don't know.

Was I lucky, or was I screwed?

Whoosh—KWA-BOOM!

I dodged a black Fist Force by a hair as it shot toward me like a beam of light. I steadied myself and sighed.

"Ah, the code of the martial world lies in ruins. Whatever happened to the noble custom of yielding three forms to a junior?"

"What?"

The squat old man with disheveled hair blinked at me.

What I'd said must have struck him as so absurd that the fist he'd been about to throw after his opening attack lowered instead.

"The code of the martial world? Yielding three forms to a junior?"

I dropped my voice.

"Indeed."

"Why are you suddenly talking like an old-fashioned gentleman and spouting nonsense? A moment ago, you told one of us bastards to stay out of it while you fought the other."

"'Bastards'? Did I say that?"

"Now you're being polite again. Either talk like you did at first or stick to that formal way of speaking. I can't keep up."

"Forgive me. I'm a junior from a much later generation. I failed to recognize my Seniors and was terribly rude."

I straightened up and even gave them a clasped-fist salute. Confusion filled the disheveled old man's eyes.

"Now you're confusing me. Aren't you Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, the Fire King's heir?"

"I am."

"Then that means you're one of those orthodox-faction types. Hearing you go on about juniors is enough to make me sick."

"What a hurtful thing to say. Aren't all those who dwell in the martial world fellow martial artists and members of one family? Besides, the Fire Gate Clan has always been a faction between the orthodox and unorthodox sides. We don't discriminate between the orthodox, demonic, or anything else. We all get along."

"And yet you're a pavilion master in the Murim Alliance?"

His eyes had already gone completely off the rails, but at least his brain still seemed to possess a minimum level of function.

A true master, however, kept his composure in any situation. I answered his sharp question without a change of expression.

“I’m actually a double agent.”

“A double agent?”

“Yes.”

“Bullshit.”

“Woof.”

“This is driving me insane.”

“I understand how you feel. But I swear to heaven, every word is true.”

“You little…”

“Did you call for me, Senior?”

The disheveled old man stared blankly at my polite demeanor before opening his mouth with a look of admiration.

“You put your heart into every stitch of that nonsense. In all my years, I’ve never met an orthodox-faction brat like you.”

I scratched the back of my head sheepishly.

“You fucking bastard. Then at least pretend to fall for it out of respect for the effort.”

“You deranged child. I might, if any of it were believable.”

“I’m embarrassed enough already. Shut up, you idiot.”

“…That tongue of yours got awfully rude, awfully fast. I could’ve sworn I was ‘Senior’ just a moment ago.”

“Going senile, old man? You’re a piece of demonic, heterodox trash who should’ve died in the Great Faction War. Who the hell do you think you are, asking to be called Senior?”

The disheveled old man stared at me for a moment as the insults poured out, then chuckled.

“You really are insane. A Disciple worthy of the Fire King.”

“Funny how everyone I meet says that when none of them have ever even seen the Fire King’s face.”

He paused, then let out a short laugh.

“How amusing. Truly amusing. You’ve barely passed twenty, and you dare talk about those days?”

“I don’t think I need to have lived through them to know.”

I shrugged.

“If a bastard like you had met him, you’d be dead. In other words, you were lucky enough to survive by avoiding the Fire King.”

"…!"

"But I think your luck runs out today."

Swish.

I raised White Flame and pointed it at him—no, at both of them. Heat shimmered above the pure-white spearhead, filled with Scorching Yang Qi.

"The Western Yao Estate. Was that your doing?"

Crack.

The smile vanished from the disheveled old man's face. He clenched his fist and stepped forward.

"Yes. This old man did it."

"I thought so. Only a lunatic would kill people that way. What about Heugung and Yohi?"

"We've kept them safe for now. Once Her Majesty the Demon Empress returns, though, those two won't have long to live."

Relief washed over me. He'd confirmed two things himself.

"Thanks for the fucking useful intel. So the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—that fucking bitch—isn't here. And those two are still in one piece."

Only then did he realize he'd said more than he needed to. His face stiffened.

"…That changes nothing. Even if Her Majesty the Demon Empress is absent, you will die by this old man's hand."

"Then why did you both come? Afraid a kid might kick your ass, so you brought your hyung[2953]?"

"You fucking brat…"

Step.

He couldn't contain his anger and took a step forward. It wouldn't have meant much to anyone watching, but that single step was exactly what I needed.

Now.

In the next instant, though, I had to stop the spear I'd been about to swing with all my strength.

Thud.

A long, withered hand as thin as a branch had caught the disheveled old man's shoulder just as he stepped forward.

"It's a provocation tactic. Don't let that bastard's three-inch tongue fool you."

So he finally stepped in.

A cold voice. A cold expression.

[2953] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Baeksang was about as chilly as a man could get, but the slender old man who'd remained silent until now was something else. No—their temperaments might be similar, but the depth was different.

His composure was as hard and cold as a glacier. So was the martial power within him.

I can't see an opening.

My instincts were telling me something clear: he was at least my equal, perhaps stronger.

Though I'd been talking to the disheveled old man, my attention had been on this one from the start.

And it seemed my opponent felt the same way.

"Impressive. No, that hardly does you justice."

The slender old man stepped forward, his admiration difficult to read.

"You unsettled your opponent with a few words, then looked for an opening to exploit. Now I understand why Her Majesty the Demon Empress warned us about you. You have martial prowess beyond your years and a calculating mind besides. You'll become a great obstacle in time."

"Am I taking a compliment the wrong way? Because it sounds like you're saying you'll kill me."

"You understood both the compliment and my intention correctly."

"Since you've already complimented me, why not let me pass? Do you really need to pull up a stone?"

"A stone lodged in the middle of the road must be removed if the path ahead is to be smooth."

"And are the two of you really skilled enough to do that?"

"You bastard! Shut your mouth!"

The disheveled old man's face twisted at the casual taunt. The slender one answered calmly.

"We'll have to do our best."

Damn it.

I suddenly had a feeling—no, the certainty—that this would be an extremely difficult fight.

When a mad dog runs wild, you can beat it down with a club. But an enemy who stays calm in any situation and doesn't underestimate you is another matter.

Even more so if that enemy possessed martial prowess that was in no way inferior to my own.

One-on-one, in a life-and-death duel, I'd have even odds against him. But he won't fight me one-on-one.

When the slightest difference can decide who lives and who dies, even a cat's paw helps. And from what I could tell, the disheveled old man was stronger than Baeksang.

Can I do this? Can I?

The instinctive doubt had barely crossed my mind when—

"Grrrr…"

Muyaho bared his teeth and growled warily. He crouched low, ready to spring at any moment, without the slightest sign of backing away.

Yeah, fuck it. If an animal that can't even talk is willing to fight, how can I back down?

Only one thing troubled me. I had a feeling I might not be able to protect him this time.

I'm sorry.

"Grrr."

I couldn't tell whether the clever White Tiger had read my eyes or understood that I wanted him, at least, to run far away.

But I was certain of one thing.

Either I would die here, or I would kill them.

Whatever happened, I wouldn't back down.

Step.

"I've never heard your names, so go peel those dicks of yours that don't even get hard anymore and eat them. Then spit out your sobriquets."

With White Flame lowered at my side, I faced them. The disheveled old man smiled with killing intent.

"Black Hand Fist Demon."

"Right, Black Hand. Never heard that one before. Guess you really are a nobody."

"I had my reasons for staying unknown. But now the whole world will hear it—the sobriquet of the man who killed the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon."

"They'll hear it without you doing that. Everyone who dies by my hand gets famous."

I answered calmly, ignored Black Hand Fist Demon as he started to flare up, and turned to the other old man.

But contrary to my wishes, the slender old man met my eyes and gave a small shake of his head.

"An enemy whose sobriquet is known is easy to assess. Isn't that right, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung?"

"…!"

"I know you, and you know nothing of me. One of us will fall here. Come when you're ready."

Damn it. This really won't be easy.

But the die was cast. It was time to see how it landed.

I awakened the fire dragon curled in my lower dantian.

Rumble-rumble-rumble—!

An aura erupted from my entire body like a volcano exploding, shaking the area in every direction. Blue-white flames layered themselves over the transparent spearhead made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, completely enveloping the spear.

Fwoosh. Sizzle-sizzle-sizzle!

The terrible heat burned away poison and evaporated moisture.

As my aura surged, Black Hand Fist Demon's drunken, unfocused gaze sharpened. A strange light flashed in the other old man's eyes, which had been frozen like eternal snow.

"Indeed…!"

Swish.

An edged weapon slid from beneath his loose sleeve, gleaming blue. Then—

SHWAAAAAAK!

The twin wheels flew from the old man's hand, tearing through the air.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

They ran without stopping.

Three tigers had become two, and five people had become four. Still, they ran. If anything, they had to move faster.

They had come too far to turn back. Doing so now would make *his* choice and sacrifice meaningless.

And perhaps thanks to him—no, thanks to Jin Taekyung—nothing stood in their way.

The tigers carried the four of them north, then farther north, before the messenger pigeon sent from the Nanman Beast Palace could arrive. The warriors of each tribe were too busy pursuing Jin Taekyung to stop them.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

They crossed the plains, climbed over mountains, and passed through swamps and rivers.

And at last, the first goal of this short yet urgent journey began to appear.

"There!"

Namho's shout was directed below the hill.

Far ahead, several hundred Nanman warriors followed one another toward the northern border.

They had finally caught up with the reconnaissance squad. Relief hit them—and with it came the thought of one man.

Jin Taekyung.

Their Pavilion Master, though they had no idea where he was or what he might be doing now.

Chapter 679

The reconnaissance squad was made up of swift-footed elites, and it showed. More than two hundred strong, they reached the northeastern border in barely three days, even with breaks along the way.

But none of them—not even the two tribal chieftains leading the squad—had expected another group of unwelcome visitors to arrive before they encountered the mysterious monster known as the Blood Monk.

And this unexpected situation was nothing compared to the news those visitors had brought.

“What… did you just say?”

“What are you talking about?”

Chief Jang and Chief Go stared wide-eyed in disbelief.

It was shocking news none of them had expected. Had it come from anyone other than the Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, they would have dismissed it as nonsense. In fact, they wished they could.

But despite their desperate wish, Yayul Mok’s answer did not change.

“It is all true.”

The truth was there in his trembling eyes. The two chieftains could only sigh as they realized it had all happened.

“What in the world…”

“Why would the Palace Lord make that choice? Why?”

Yayul Mok clenched his fists so tightly that blood ran from his palms before opening his mouth.

“My father had already guessed that he would be unable to resist the tide of events once so many chieftains had joined hands with Uncle Baek—no, with Baeksang.”

“Even so, did he bring this danger upon himself just to save a few Han Chinese?”

“He did not bring it upon himself.”

“What?”

“My father said this when he sent me and the others to the underground prison. He said that repaying a righteous act with righteousness was keeping faith, and that turning away from someone who had helped us was injustice. So today, I intend to stake my fate on keeping faith. On those two people—Jin Taekyung and Baeksang.”

“…!”

“…!”

The two chieftains closed their eyes with low groans.

Having served at the Beast Miao King’s side for a long time, they had vaguely guessed what kind of person he was and what choices he would make.

But…

“This time, the Palace Lord was wrong. He should have gathered all the strength of the tribes that followed him and the Miao people, then executed the traitors in the Inner Palace.”

“Even if we give Jin Taekyung every benefit of the doubt, trusting him may have been the right choice. If the Young Palace Lord’s story is true, Jin Taekyung ultimately left alone in order to keep faith. But Baeksang is different.”

As the two chieftains spoke with such certainty, Yayul Mok, who had been looking at them with a trace of hope, opened his mouth.

“It is too early to judge. If Baeksang granted my father’s request…”

“Young Palace Lord.”

Chief Jang cut him off, his voice hollow.

“‘Subdue the Han Chinese in the reconnaissance squad and escort them to the Inner Palace.‘ That is the first and last missive we received. Do you understand what it means?”

Yayul Mok faltered. Behind him, Namho, who had been watching quietly, suddenly understood. He spoke almost in a groan.

“He kept them in the dark on purpose.”

“Elder Namho, you mean…”

“There is no need to say more. The two chieftains here and the warriors in the reconnaissance squad are all people who follow the Palace Lord. If they were told about the trouble in the Inner Palace, they would surely interfere somehow. He probably intended to call them back after everything was finished. Or…”

Namho’s gaze darkened.

“Or… the Blood Monk. He may have planned to let that old monster deal with them.”

“…!”

“A borrowed knife to kill others. Baeksang and Dark Heaven chose a useful blade. No, in this situation, it isn’t even someone else’s blade. There is a strong possibility that the Blood Monk is in league with them as well.”

A cold silence settled over the group. Namho saw their shaken faces and felt his heart sink.

This is bad. The worst.

Behind them lay the Nanman Beast Palace, likely in Baeksang and Dark Heaven’s hands by now. Ahead stood a mysterious Supreme Peak master they could not face alone.

And Jin Taekyung, the one person they could count on most, was not here.

What are we supposed to do?

Even after a lifetime in the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, Namho had no easy answer. But he had to decide before it was too late.

Amid the suffocating feeling that invisible chains were wrapped around his entire body, Namho finally forced his lips apart.

“Where are the others?”

Chief Jang understood.

“If you mean the Han Chinese, we detained them as a precaution. We did them no harm—only struck their Sleep Acupoints.”

“…”

“You intend to send them back to the Central Plains?”

The question caught Namho squarely off guard. After a brief silence, Namho nodded heavily.

“I’m sorry. But for now, this is the best option. If they cross the Yangtze and report what is happening in Nanman, the Murim Alliance will never stand by and do nothing.”

“…The Murim Alliance.”

“I was born in Nanman and spent half my life in the Central Plains. Though I am nothing more than a powerless old man, I am someone who understands the circumstances of both Nanman and the Central Plains better than anyone. If it is the Murim Alliance I know, they will find a way to help Nanman.”

His voice was calm, but his resolve was unmistakable.

Beyond the dense grass where they were lying in ambush, the two chieftains gazed at the broad, endless waters of the Yangtze before opening their mouths with sighs.

“Damn it.”

“What should we do?”

Namho had already made up his mind.

“There are two ways. First, release the Han Chinese, leave this place at once, avoid Baeksang’s eyes, and wait for the right moment. Second, head to the Central Plains together with the Han Chinese.”

“Head to the Central Plains together? There is no ship of sufficient size anywhere around here. How are we supposed to—”

“There is. A ship that can take everyone.”

They turned toward the sudden voice. Sama Pyo was staggering to his feet, supported by Taishan.

“Is that true?” Chief Jang asked.

At Chief Jang’s question, Sama Pyo answered with a pale face.

“How do you think we got all the way to Nanman?”

“Do you mean…”

"The swift ship of the Yangtze River Channel League is not far from here. It's half a day to the west. If we travel for even half that time, we might be able to rendezvous with it."

Hope lit the two chieftains' faces.

If they followed a tributary of the Yangtze as far as Sichuan, they would be within the reach of the Central Plains Murim. Even if Baeksang and Dark Heaven held the Nanman Beast Palace, reinforcements from the Murim Alliance—with the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families at their head—could turn the situation around.

There are already three prestigious great sects in Sichuan alone. Even if the Murim Alliance's official reinforcements are delayed, those three will be different.

Namho calmly considered their prospects.

The Emei Sect. The Qingcheng Sect. The Sichuan Tang Clan.

Even though they had shed much blood and weakened during the Sichuan Bloodbath, their roots ran deep and firm enough that even Dark Heaven could not tear them out in a single stroke.

Moreover, all three sects considered Jin Taekyung their Benefactor. If they answered the call, gathered the strength of Sichuan Murim, and headed for Nanman…

Seven days and nights to return, if we're fast. Ten days at most.

Namho was neither a hot-blooded youth nor a martial artist who trusted in his own martial arts. That was why his judgment was colder and more accurate than anyone else's in this place.

Lead them back the way we came, and we'll surely die. Bring the Central Plains to our aid, and we have a real chance. Until then, Jin Taekyung and the Beast Miao King will have to…

He could only trust that they would hold out. That they would still be alive when the others returned.

Even Namho himself could not quite believe in that hope. Then, as he held on to it —

Boom. Boom. Booooom!

Namho heard it. No—everyone hidden in the forest above the endless river could see and hear it.

A low drumbeat. A sleek hull approaching on the currents of the Yangtze.

"What is that…?"

"The Yangtze River Channel League! It's their swift ship!"

But the next moment, the two chieftains, who had been celebrating with brightened faces, sensed something strange and fell silent.

The swift ship should have been at least half a day to the west. Why was it here?

They saw the rigid expressions on Namho's and Sama Pyo's faces, and their puzzlement turned to dread. Namho spoke through a groan.

"Prepare for battle."

"…!"

Fear swept through the group. Namho thought of the one person who was not at his side—the one he needed now more than ever.

Damn it. I'm sorry.

They might die before they could save him.

Crash. Boom.

The hull cut through the water without slowing and drove hard onto the sandy shore.

And then…

Step.

Where a wave had swept over the sand, one person's footstep was etched into it.

Whoosh!

Two streaks of light cut through the air.

Despite their strange movements, the twin wheels came at me like flashes of light. I swung White Flame diagonally downward to meet them.

KWA-BOOM! Rumble-rumble!

A tremendous roar erupted as a shockwave tore through the area and shook the air. But it was not over yet.

My five senses, sharp as blades, caught every movement of the twin wheels behind me.

They're coming again.

As Muyaho slid backward, I caught him by the nape and twisted my body.

Whoosh—shhk!

A blue flash skimmed past me. I heard a sharp slicing sound and saw the White Tiger's snow-white fur scatter through the air.

In my tilted field of vision, another sight came into view: a wild-haired freak charging at me like a mad bison.

"You bastard—!"

The Black Hand Fist Demon.

Black Force layered itself over his dark fist, and then he shot it straight toward my chest.

Whoom!

I felt the air ripple. Felt the terrifying power behind that punch. But…

That won't be enough.

With a brief mutter, I straightened the body I had twisted as far as it would go. By then, the black Force had already reached point-blank range and was giving off an ominous light.

Beyond it, the Black Hand Fist Demon's eyes gleamed with madness. They seemed to say, *You're dead now.*

I had seen that certainty in the eyes of many enemies before.

From Third Rate swordsmen to Supreme Peak masters. Regardless of their level of martial arts, they had always worn that expression.

And when everything was over, I was always the one still standing on two feet.

Swish.

In the slowed-down world, the cool feel of the spear shaft slipped away from my hand.

The Black Hand Fist Demon had closed in so deftly that my spear had lost its advantage. Without a moment's hesitation, I let go and struck with my palm.

KWA-BOOM!

Two differently colored Forces collided with a roar. Everything within a radius of ten-odd jang[2954] melted beneath the horrific heat, and the Black Hand Fist Demon's eyes flew wide open.

"You…"

One clash was enough for each of us to measure the other's strength.

Even though the twin wheels had made me react half a beat late, I had easily blocked the Black Hand Fist Demon's punch. Looking into his wavering eyes, I spoke calmly.

"A nobody. Right?"

"…!"

He knew something had gone wrong. Too late.

I clenched my other, empty hand.

Fwoosh.

Blue-white flames surged around my fist.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

KWA-AAANG!

[2954] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Ten-odd jang is roughly 30 meters (100 ft).

Chapter 680

The world crept by.

Blue-white flames surged around my fist, feeding on every sight that flashed past in that fraction of a second.

The punch I drove like a cannonball toward the Black Hand Fist Demon's heart.

His bulging eyes and the hand he thrust out in haste.

The black Force giving way despite his efforts, and his Body-Protecting Qi shattering the instant it touched the flames.

Even the dazzling flash that came slicing through the space beyond them.

KWA-AAANG!

A tremendous roar. A violent tremor.

Everything happened in an instant, and ended just as quickly. Then a blast of hot air swept across the place.

No—the blast swept across everything within several dozen jang.[2955]

Mist born from the heat and steam of Scorching Yang Qi spread everywhere, blocking my view.

Whoosh…

I stood still, staring into the pale mist, until a voice drifted out of it.

"Truly astonishing. More than I expected."

There was a faint note of genuine admiration in his voice. I drew White Flame back with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space and answered calmly.

"I'm pretty good for my age. I doubt even the Heavenly Demon or Martial God was this good."

"How arrogant. Still, I'll grant you that. You've earned the right to say it."

"Listen to you talking about what I've earned. You got scared and interfered, and now you're saying that?"

My voice sounded calm, but I was bitter inside.

Damn it.

That flash I'd seen at the last moment. If it hadn't been for the twin wheels the slender old man had thrown, the Black Hand Fist Demon might have suffered a severe internal injury—or died on the spot.

I expected him to interfere, but his timing was too damn good.

I'd had only two choices: finish off the Black Hand Fist Demon and let the twin wheels take my head, making me a Dullahan candidate, or let him go and save my own life.

Naturally, I'd chosen the latter.

[2955] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

I changed the direction of my punch in midair and struck the twin wheels aside. The Black Hand Fist Demon did not even dare try to take advantage of the opening. He hurriedly pulled back.

The clash had started and ended in the blink of an eye. It might have looked like a draw, but I'd lost far more.

Having learned what I could do to him, the Black Hand Fist Demon would fight me with a caution he'd never shown before. An opponent's carelessness was a weakness greater than any other, but you only got one chance to exploit it.

At this rate…

This wouldn't be easy. No, it had become an incredibly difficult fight.

I searched for the figure hidden beyond the mist and called out.

"Black Hand? My dear Black Hand, who's had fifty more years than me to learn martial arts and apparently learned them through his asshole instead. Where are you hiding?"

I thought he might ignore me. But the Black Hand Fist Demon was considerate enough to give my question his full attention.

"…Shut your damn mouth."

"Is it just me, or are you talking a lot quieter than before? Did a taste of fire shrink your balls too?"

"…You bastard. You caught me off guard once, and now you're full of yourself. Do you think you'll get another chance?"

I let out a short laugh.

Given his martial prowess, he wasn't entirely wrong to say I'd caught him off guard. But that was the kind of excuse a young prodigy made, not an old monster who'd lived as long as he had.

"You sound like a fucking idiot, and you know it. Right?"

"You—tearing you apart wouldn't be enough…!"

"Enough."

A cold voice cut off the Black Hand Fist Demon's shout. A slender figure emerged from the mist still blanketing the area.

Step.

Mud baked hard by the terrible heat crumbled like sand beneath the old man's foot.

He held a wheel in each hand, blades jutting from them like the teeth of gears. He gave his sleeves a light shake.

Whoosh…

A cold wind settled over the heat and swept away the mist, revealing what had become of the poisonous marshland around us.

It looked like a desert.

“So this is the Fire Gate Divine Technique I’ve heard so much about. Impressive. What stage have you reached?”

His admiration sounded genuine. I lowered my spearhead and answered.

“Three thousand twenty-five.”

“Is it just me, or is that a ridiculous number?”

“The realm of martial arts has no end.”

“A foolish question met with a wise answer. The Fire King raised his Disciple well.”

“He did, didn’t he? So why did your parents raise *their* kid like this?”

A parent insult, thrown hard and tight on the inside. The old man didn’t flinch.

“I suppose I’ll ask them if I ever find myself in the afterlife.”

Step.

He walked forward as if out for a stroll. I measured the distance between us.

“Since you brought it up, why not visit them today?”

“Unfortunately, I don’t expect to go anywhere near there for some time.”

“You shouldn’t put that off. Think how angry your parents must be in the Nine Springs. They worked their asses off raising you, and you won’t even visit.”

“You’ve guessed wrong this time. I’m an orphan, with no family in this world. No one cared for me growing up, so I can hardly be accused of being an unfilial son.”

Step.

His third step.

Muyaho had gone from a majestic White Tiger to Poppy after a disastrous grooming job with the twin wheels. He gave a low growl. I watched the wheels begin to turn slowly in the old man’s hands and muttered,

“Then you won’t be able to ask why they raised you this way when you get to the Nine Springs. You don’t know what they look like.”

“Now that you mention it, you’re right. Thank you for the advice.”

“What about the idiot creeping along behind you?”

The Black Hand Fist Demon spat out a brief curse. The old man answered calmly.

“Black Hand? He’s in a similar position.”

“I’m genuinely curious. Is that a requirement for joining Dark Heaven, or is it just a trend?”

The old man took another step instead of answering.

Step.

The sound rang unusually clear in my ears. At that moment, I saw blue light blaze from the twin wheels in his hands.

Hiss! Whoosh!

Two streaks of light flew toward me with faint sounds of splitting air. The twin wheels twisted through the air like living snakes. Beneath them, the Black Hand Fist Demon charged, madness gleaming in his eyes.

SHWAAAAAAK!

An attack from two directions. No—from three at once.

“GRAAAH!”

As the White Tiger roared behind me, I brought White Flame’s spearhead down with all my strength.

KWAANG!

The impact sent a violent jolt through my arms. I knocked one wheel aside, felt wind from my blind spot, and turned my head.

Whoosh—shhk!

It missed by a hair. Strands of hair severed by Force scattered through the air as the Black Hand Fist Demon closed to within three jang of me and snapped his tattered sleeves.

“Youuu!”

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Palm Force burst from his outstretched hands, shaking the space around us. I eased my spearhead into the black Force rolling toward me like a wave.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear. First form.

Fire Dragon’s Single Tail.

Fwoosh—shaaaa!

Blue-white flames surged. The fire dragon’s tail split the black Palm Force and shot straight toward him. The Black Hand Fist Demon cried out in alarm and twisted aside.

Shhk!

A sharp cutting sound.

Unlike me, he hadn’t escaped with a few lost hairs. Blood dripped from the blunt end of his nose, whose tip had been sliced off before he knew it.

“You—you dare…”

I knew it now. Even if we fought ten more times, the Black Hand Fist Demon could never defeat me.

That old monster’s towering pride and the anger buried in his heart clouded his judgment. The smallest crack in it was an opening for me.

Now.

Flash!

One step.

The several jang between us vanished. More than a dozen possible moves flashed through my mind, and choosing one was easy.

Whoosh!

From sky to earth, my spearhead came down with a faint hiss. Blue-white flames rose along its edge.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear. Second form.

Heavenly Strike.

Fwoosh—KWA-AAANG!

A snowball grows as it rolls. A current swells into a wave when more water joins it.

The Black Hand Fist Demon looked up at the streak of flame crossing the air. His eyes flew wide.

“Guh…!”

With a startled cry, he thrust up both palms. The Palm Force he hastily summoned met the flames and faded away. In that brief instant, blue flashes came from my left and right.

SHWIIIIING!

My neck. My chest.

I couldn’t dodge both by moving. I made my decision in a split second and twisted the spearhead away from the Black Hand Fist Demon, swinging it at the wheels.

KWAANG!

Even someone like me couldn’t overcome the verdict contained in those four characters: *force majeure*.

SHRAAAK!

The tremendous rebound threw me off balance and sent me sliding helplessly backward. A pale figure rushed in like a ghost.

Shrik!

Not a word. Not even a breath.

Until now, the old man had stayed back and thrown his twin wheels. Now he entered the fight himself—calm and cold, each movement timed and placed with precision.

Just as he did now.

SHWAAK! THUD!

Hot and cold.

Though I twisted aside at the last moment, it made little difference.

Finger Qi erupted from the tips of fingers long and withered as tree branches and pierced my shoulder. White Flame’s spearhead, which had been driving toward the old man, wavered off course.

Dodging the weakened spearhead was easy for him.

Whoosh!

My spearhead cut uselessly through empty air. Gritting my teeth, I steadied myself and opened my free hand. Flames roiled around it as I drove my palm toward the old man's chest.

Fwoosh—whoooom!

The Flame Divine Palm surged forward, burning everything in its path. I saw its flames reflected in his eyes, their heat beyond description, burning without pause.

Yet his eyes remained cold. A chill I couldn't explain ran through me.

This is…

And the ominous instinct that seized my entire body soon revealed itself as reality.

Sss…

In a moment divided into fractions of a fraction, the old man slowly extended his hand.

No. He wasn't the only one moving slowly.

My palm advanced toward his chest just as slowly. Behind each of us, the Black Hand Fist Demon and the White Tiger were charging toward the other.

Then cold flowed from the old man's wrinkled hand, and time began moving again.

KRAK! SHHHHTZZZ!

Our palms met at last. Blue-white flames collided and mingled with pure-white cold.

KRRRUMBLE!

Everything was hot and cold at once.

Two lights of different colors flashed without cease before my eyes.
Unprecedented internal energy shattered and shook everything around us.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A roar like heaven and earth splitting apart.

And I saw it. At the same time, I heard it.

"I'm late introducing myself."

Powerful Yin-Cold Qi pressed down on the flames as they slowly died away.

"I am called the Great Snow Fiend."

The cold voice drifted through a cloud of pure-white breath.

KRAAASH!

Chapter 681

For an instant, I wondered.

What if the Black Hand Fist Demon hadn't been there? What if I'd dodged the Finger Qi?

What if the pain hadn't risen from the shoulder pierced by the Finger Qi at the exact moment our palms met?

What if I had known that my opponent's martial arts were based on Yin-Cold Qi?

If—if any of that had been different…

Who would be standing now?

But I had no time to find the answer.

KRAK!

The frozen flames died away. The Yin-Cold Qi that had swallowed even the fire swelled as though it might burst.

Beyond the unprecedented internal energy that shook the surrounding space, someone's hand, engulfed in pure-white light, pressed against my chest.

Tap.

One thought filled my mind.

Cold.

KRAAANG!

A storm of cold swept out in every direction.

At its center, a fierce wind battered my entire body. The world flashed past, and an immense force slammed through my back.

KRRRUNCH!

Trees. Rocks. Grass. Even unknown creatures unlucky enough to be caught in my path.

Alive or dead, it made no difference.

Everything I struck as I flew backward like a misfired shell bent, shattered, or burst apart.

The thick stone wall standing across my path—a path I had no control over—was both a curse and a blessing.

KWAANG! RRRUMBLE!

Even through the haze, I could feel the excruciating pain.

The scenery finally stopped whipping past. So did I, after flying several dozen jang[2956] and burying myself deep in the stone wall.

Goddamn it.

I strained to speak, but no sound made it past my lips.

[2956] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

The world was red and blurry. A constant ringing filled my ears.

BEEP! BEEP! BEEP!

That was a little unusual, even for ringing ears.

"…Fuck."

I raised my head with a hollow mutter.

More than a dozen holographic windows floated in the air. Instead of their usual clear chimes, they came with warning beeps.

That got me good.

I let out a bitter laugh. Pain rose without pause from injury after injury. The Yin-Cold Qi that had invaded my body left my hands and feet trembling, making a mockery of my Unaffected by Cold and Heat realm.

I have to get up. I have to fight again…

But my body wouldn't listen. It felt as though every screw in it had come loose.

I was cold and tired.

If I closed my eyes, I felt like I could get a good night's sleep for the first time in ages.

Yes. No dreams, no one waking me. I'd sleep until my back hurt, and everything would be better.

When I woke, the pain wracking my body would be gone. This goddamn body would work again. I'd curl up under a warm microfiber blanket and look at my smartphone, and Mom's voice would come through the crack in the door.

"Jin Taekyung, Jin Hayeon. I've got dinner ready, so hurry up and come out."

Then I'd shuffle into the kitchen and, despite what she'd just said, find the table empty. I'd set out the spoons and side dishes while Mom stood with her back to me, the savory smell of soybean-paste stew wafting over her shoulder.

Ah. This is nice.

Just thinking about it put me at ease.

The corners of my mouth rose, and my eyelids sank lower.

Sss…

Something rough and damp brushed across my face.

I slowly opened my eyes. The first things I saw were sharp teeth and clear blue-white eyes.

—Whine.

The White Tiger whined like a puppy as soon as our eyes met. I gave a quiet laugh.

"…Was that you?"

—Whine. Whiiine.

I couldn't understand him, but I could tell what his cries meant. What he wanted to say.

"Phew."

Breathing hurt.

It felt as though I'd woken from a long dream. So many thoughts had passed through my mind, but only a short time had gone by.

Crumbled stone rained down on my body, still lodged deep in a wall so thick I couldn't judge its depth.

Only a few seconds had passed since I'd taken the blow. There was still time.

Thud.

I braced a hand trembling from the cold against the ground and muttered, "Stop crying. I'm not dead yet."

I was answering him, but I was telling myself, too.

That was right. I was not dead yet, and even if my flame had briefly gone cold, it could flare up again and again.

Just like now.

Fwoooosh.

Internal energy surged from my lower dantian, heating hundreds of acupoints before spreading through my limbs and bones.

As I temporarily sealed the damage inside me, fiery pain swept through my body. Something surged up my throat.

Cough!

Dark red blood spilled from my lips. I paid it no mind. It was dead blood.

And the substance that had been gnawing away at my body and interfering with the flow of my internal energy was covered in pure-white frost the instant it touched the ground.

Fsssh.

Yin-Cold Qi. An extreme form of it unlike anything I had ever seen.

During the Shaolin Bloodshed, the Yin Freak—one of the Yin-Yang Twin Freaks who had led Dark Heaven's martial artists in a surprise attack on Shaolin Temple—had not possessed anything like this.

"…So that's how it is."

After muttering under my breath, I rose without hesitation.

Tududduk.

Leaves and stone dust fell from my body at the sudden movement. A dull ache followed, but fresh warmth now filled me from within. My hand had stopped trembling, and my vision cleared enough to make out the two figures drawing near.

Step.

Footsteps slowly crossed the Poisonblood Grounds, which had changed from a swamp into a desert, and from a desert into frost-covered land.

The Black Hand Fist Demon followed several paces behind with a triumphant look on his face. I had eyes only for the man ahead of him.

That damn old man.

He walked at his leisure, as though admiring a landscape he had painted himself. I raised White Flame at an angle and watched him.

"Unexpected," he said. "I was certain you wouldn't be able to move after that."

I knew his sobriquet now. Or perhaps it was more accurate to say I'd remembered it.

"That might be true for old men like you, Great Snow Fiend."

"Youth is a fine thing. Yet you fail to understand that, in a situation like this, it will only bring you more pain."

As he had until now, the Great Snow Fiend answered without the slightest wavering and continued.

"The fight is over. Surrender now, and I will spare your life. This is my first and last offer."

"Senior! What are you saying?"

That wasn't me. The Black Hand Fist Demon's face twisted as he protested, but the Great Snow Fiend shook his head.

"The Demon Empress gave me the order herself. She said that letting him live would invite great trouble in the future, but that I was to capture him alive if possible. And we already have the upper hand."

"Even so…!"

"Shut your mouth."

"…"

"I know how you feel, but this is Heaven's business. Question me again, and I will not forgive you."

His tone and aura were icy. Even the half-mad Black Hand Fist Demon knew better than to keep arguing.

"This fucking…"

The Great Snow Fiend ignored the mutter slipping through the other man's clenched teeth and held out a hand to me.

"It is foolish to continue a fight whose outcome is clear. Surrender and live to fight another day. Do that, and the Fire Gate Clan and the Jin Family of Taiyuan may preserve their lineages."

I stared at him and answered.

Not with words, but with action.

Whoosh!

A sharp sound of air splitting rang through the air.

The Great Snow Fiend moved exactly half a step to avoid my spear strike.

“I believe I made myself clear. My first and last offer.”

“So?”

“I thought you were fairly clever, but you’ve chosen the foolish path after all. Can you not feel which way the battle has turned?”

“Which way it’s turned.”

I muttered the words and continued.

“Honestly, I do want to live. But I’m not the kind of bastard who surrenders or runs just because things have tilted a little. Unlike some people.”

The Great Snow Fiend paused. Then, as though he’d realized something, he gave a small nod.

“You know me.”

“I’ve heard of a sobriquet or two. White Rice Cake, Great Snow Fiend, something like that.”[2957]

“A child like you would hardly have heard that name… Fire King Jeok Cheongang. Did your master tell you?”

“Then do you think the fucking Heavenly Demon told me?”

I shrugged.

“He said if I ever met a son of a bitch who used twin wheels and Yin-Cold Qi, it would be the Great Snow Fiend or his successor. He said he wished he’d killed you himself, but after you killed the former Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect, you disappeared without a trace.”

“I feel the same regret. If this old man had met your master during the Great Faction War, I could have killed the Fire King and made my name resound throughout the world.”

“At best, you’d have been the Ice God instead of the Great Snow Fiend, you fucking idiot.”[2958]

“…”

For the first time, he reacted. It was slight, but his brow furrowed. I gave a quiet laugh.

“So you do have some pride. Then again, you ran away back then. Maybe you don’t.”

“I merely withdrew to fight another day. This old man is not foolish enough to stake his life on a fight when outnumbered.”

In truth, from what I’d heard, his decision had been cold and sound. He’d killed the former Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect, thrown their chain of command into chaos, then slipped away from Great Snow Mountain and vanished.

But…

[2957] *Baekseolgi* is a white Korean steamed rice cake; its name sounds similar to *daeseolgwi*.

[2958] *Bingsin* (“Ice God”) sounds like *byeongsin*, a harsh Korean insult meaning “idiot.”

“So what?”

“What?”

“You were scared, so you ran. You didn’t want to die. You were afraid of dying. That’s why you stayed hidden for so long.”

“You bastard…”

“It’s not like I’m criticizing you. I don’t want to die either. But once you’ve lived that many years, you should be honest every now and then—even about the things you don’t want to admit. Don’t you think?”

Deep lines creased the Great Snow Fiend’s brow. Powerful Yin-Cold Qi rose around him and pressed down on everything nearby.

“I heard you. When I next meet your master, I shall pass on your last words.”

Last words.

Maybe that’s how it will be.

I took a deep breath. This was no ordinary opponent. Facing two Supreme Peak masters while suffering from internal injuries was all but suicide.

Was I afraid of dying? Of course.

I’d feared death ever since I became a Hunter. Coming to Murim hadn’t changed that.

Now that I had taken one step toward accepting the word *death* in my heart, I was different from before.

I can do anything. Anything.

This wasn’t a fight to survive. It was a fight to kill.

And that meant I could charge in without holding my life back.

SHWAAAAAK!

Chapter 682

SHWAAAAK!

As Jin Taekyung charged straight toward him, the Great Snow Fiend thought, *Yes. Come.*

The boy's sharp tongue had unsettled him for the first time in years, but it changed nothing. He had long since put aside the fact that his opponent was barely twenty, still a boy by any ordinary measure.

How could he afford to think of him that way? By the Great Snow Fiend's reckoning, Jin Taekyung was a monster almost without precedent in history.

Even the Three Saints and Ten Kings—giants who had left their mark on Murim history—had not reached Supreme Peak until they were at least thirty. Jin Taekyung had done it at an absurdly young age.

Terrifying talent. And an absurdly young age.

Alongside Cheongpung of Huashan, the other genius who had inherited Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's teachings, he was certain to become one of their most dangerous obstacles.

At the very least, within the next fifty years, he will grow into a monster capable of matching the Martial God and Heavenly Demon. He must be dealt with now.

The Great Snow Fiend did not know exactly why his direct superior, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, had ordered Jin Taekyung captured alive. At this moment, though, he trusted his own judgment.

Demon Empress, you are wrong this time. He… must never be allowed to live.

As he addressed her in thoughts she would never hear, the twin wheels within his sleeves let out a harsh howl.

WOOOOONG!

His martial arts and identity had already been exposed. There was nothing to gain by holding back.

The Great Snow Fiend focused every sense on Jin Taekyung's rapidly approaching figure. His eyes flashed.

Now!

SHWING!

The rapidly spinning twin wheels left his wrinkled hand.

SHWAAAAK!

Filled with extreme Yin-Cold Qi, the twin wheels froze the space around them as they shot forward. The two blades traced grotesque paths according to the Great Snow Fiend's will. At the point where they descended, Jin Taekyung had already

closed to within three jang.[2959]

KWAANG!

Blue and white flashes mingled with a tremendous roar. Fire met ice.

With a single swing, Jin Taekyung knocked the twin wheels away, then burst through the mistlike steam that had settled over the ground.

SHWAAK!

He looked as swift as ever, but the Great Snow Fiend's sharp eyes caught the difference.

He's suppressing it for now. His internal injuries are still affecting him.

It was slight, but unmistakable. His movements had lost some of their precision, and his momentum had grown rougher.

To the Great Snow Fiend, Jin Taekyung looked like a wounded beast: claws still sharp, but tiring fast.

And the Great Snow Fiend was a seasoned hunter who knew better than anyone how to hunt such a beast.

At this rate, bringing him down is only a matter of time.

He even had a hunting dog beside him—the Black Hand Fist Demon. Not strong enough to sink its teeth into the beast's neck, perhaps, but savage enough to charge in on the hunter's behalf.

PAT-PAT!

"Black Hand!"

The hunter moved back. The hunting dog moved forward.

The Great Snow Fiend sprang back exactly as far as Jin Taekyung had advanced. At his shout, the Black Hand Fist Demon charged.

"Youuu!"

With a furious roar, he unleashed dozens of palm strikes packed with powerful internal energy.

KRAAAAA!

Black Force surged toward Jin Taekyung like a wave. At the same moment, the spear in his hand blurred.

SHWAAAAK!

Supreme Peak—a realm only the chosen could enter.

The young monster who had reached it at barely twenty thrust out his spear without hesitation. Blue-white flames coiled around the spearhead as it drove into the center of the black wave.

BOOM!

One strike, aimed precisely at one point.

[2959] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three jang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); twenty jang are about 60.6 m (199 ft).

Jin Taekyung split the wave of Force and burst through it. The Great Snow Fiend swept both hands downward, and the wheels Jin Taekyung had knocked away plunged from where they circled overhead.

SHWIIIIING!

They moved like living creatures.

Some might have called it Seizing an Object Through Empty Space, or Snake Sword, a technique performed with cords or threads. Both would have been wrong.

The Great Snow Fiend's will alone moved the wheels. Powered solely by his Middle Dantian, they carried a single purpose.

Die.

Killing intent as cold as ice, directed at one man.

The two wheels bent in different directions and descended like flashes of light. At the same time, the Black Hand Fist Demon's figure shot forward, trailing a savage momentum.

SHWING! SHWAAAAK!

Three flashes converged from three directions.

The Great Snow Fiend looked at Jin Taekyung, standing at the intersection of death, and felt certain.

If he clashes with Black Hand now, he won't come away unharmed. He'll retreat, and I'll use that opening to…

Jin Taekyung rendered the rest of the plan useless.

PAT!

He advanced. Not an inch of retreat, not a moment of hesitation.

His spear flashed toward the wheels above his head. Then he drove out a fist like the forepaw of a tiger charging from the edge of a cliff.

KWAANG! KRRRUNCH!

The Great Snow Fiend saw it clearly.

THOOM!

Within the tremendous roar that sounded as if the sky were splitting apart and the flash of light that followed, a spear rose over Jin Taekyung's shoulder.

SHWIIIIK! SHRAK!

He had lost his grip on his treasured weapon. As he clashed with the Black Hand Fist Demon, the twin wheels slashed across his shoulder like lightning.

SHRAK! FWOOSH!

Bright-red blood sprayed like a fountain. Jin Taekyung staggered.

At this wholly unexpected development that had unfolded in an instant, even the normally cold Great Snow Fiend faltered. He could not retrieve the twin wheels buried deep in the stone wall.

Why would he choose that?

He could not understand it. In Jin Taekyung's place, he would have dodged without a second thought.

But his thoughts could go no further.

RRRRUMBLE!

A shock wave burst from Jin Taekyung and the Black Hand Fist Demon, shaking the space around them. Their fists had met in midair and now trembled, neither advancing nor giving way.

An even match.

The thought flashed through the Great Snow Fiend's mind, and his figure blurred.

SHWIK!

Jin Taekyung was exhausted from his successive injuries. The fact that the Black Hand Fist Demon—despite being a Supreme Peak master like him, clearly a level below—had managed to match him for even a brief moment was proof.

The chance had come sooner than expected. The Great Snow Fiend was too practiced a hunter to miss it.

Now is the perfect time.

Even if it was wounded and bleeding, a beast was still a beast. The hunting dog called the Black Hand Fist Demon could never handle that young beast on its own.

Unless the hunter—the only one capable of tearing out the beast's throat—stepped forward.

I must kill him. Right now.

His decision took an instant. His body shot forward like lightning.

FSSSH. At every step, Yin-Cold Qi flowed from him and froze the air.

In three steps, he crossed more than twenty jang. Over the Black Hand Fist Demon's shoulder, he caught sight of his prey.

Jin Taekyung.

He could see him. Sense him.

Haa. Hah.

Ragged breaths. A pale face. The upper body the wheels had grazed was soaked in bright-red blood. As Jin Taekyung spotted the hunter bearing down on him, his eyes began to tremble.

I was right.

Certainty settled into the Great Snow Fiend's cold gaze.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. Heir to the Fire Gate Clan and successor to the Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

The Divine Dragon of the Central Plains, who would one day become a new Martial God and look down upon the world, would die before he ever rose above the clouds.

Today. Here.

The time for the hunt had finally arrived.

Ssssss.

Wind blew across the ground, bringing cold to air and earth that had briefly grown hot. It would cover mountains, rivers, trees, and grasses with frost.

For one man, that snow wind brought despair. For another, hope.

He's here. He came!

The Black Hand Fist Demon barely held back a cheer.

He did not like the Great Snow Fiend. Given how the man usually treated him, even that was putting it mildly. The Great Snow Fiend always spoke to him as though he were a servant and looked at him as though he were far beneath him. If his martial arts had been strong enough, he might have killed the man long ago without alerting the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

But right now, the Great Snow Fiend was worth an army.

Watching Jin Taekyung hurriedly try to pull away, the Black Hand Fist Demon smiled with mad delight.

You bastard disciple of the Fire Gate Clan. Even tearing you apart limb by limb wouldn't be enough. You will never escape.

KRRUNCH!

His hooked fingers closed around Jin Taekyung's fist just as it was about to fall. It was a grappling technique he had practiced for as long as his fist technique.

ZZZT. Heat like lava seared his hands, threatening to set them alight, but he did not care.

He needed only a moment. Then both the pain and Jin Taekyung's life would end.

The Black Hand Fist Demon looked into Jin Taekyung's wide-open eyes and shouted as though cheering.

"Senior!"

The Great Snow Fiend answered before the shout had ended.

He drove an ice sword created solely from extreme Yin-Cold Qi into the Black Hand Fist Demon's back.

SQUELCH!

"…!"

In the slowed world, flesh tore and the Black Hand Fist Demon's body went rigid.

The Great Snow Fiend cared nothing for the reaction of a hunting dog that had served its purpose. His cold gaze remained fixed ahead, on Jin Taekyung's eyes, wide with pain and shock.

Or so it should have.

The former Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect had worn that look when they met long ago on Great Snow Mountain. So had the Black Hand Fist Demon in the instant before his death.

Jin Taekyung should have been pierced and killed by the ice sword filled with powerful Yin-Cold Qi.

But…

What is this?

The Great Snow Fiend's gaze, frozen as though it could not move, trembled.

His eyes slowly lowered.

There, he saw someone's hand pressed against his chest.

At the same moment he had thrust his ice sword—no, a fraction of a moment before—this hand had pierced through the Black Hand Fist Demon's chest. It was red and blue, blue and dazzling.

FWOOSH.

The heat was enough to burn flesh and bone. Even the soul within.

As he stared at the blood-soaked blue-white hellfire, the Great Snow Fiend spoke in a voice that seemed to boil.

"How? How did you…?"

Jin Taekyung's calm voice reached his ear.

"You should've stabbed a little higher. Unless you were trying to give me EXP."

What?

The Great Snow Fiend wanted to ask again. Jin Taekyung gave him no chance.

BOOM!

Through the terrible heat burning across his body, the Great Snow Fiend saw it.

That's…

The Black Hand Fist Demon's collapsing body.

And an unidentified red armor draped across Jin Taekyung's upper body.

KRRRUNCH!

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BOOM!

Scorching heat tore through the Great Snow Fiend's chest.

KRRRUNCH!

An immense impact swept through his entire body like a wave.

He coughed, and dark-red blood burst between his parted lips. His vision, clear a moment ago, grew hazy. It had been a long time since he had felt pain like this.

But as he crashed through a massive ten-thousand-geun[2960] boulder, what tormented him most was neither the pain nor his internal injuries.

He saw through my move? That brat?

He had defeated countless powerful enemies to reach this point. Now a young man barely twenty had outmaneuvered him. The thought made his head spin.

My judgment should have been correct.

He muttered the words blankly inside his mind, then shook his head.

No. It *had* been correct.

His formidable martial arts were not the only reason he had survived this insane Murim and its countless brushes with death.

Hide yourself. Know your opponent.

If his Supreme Peak martial arts were a sharp sword, his unwavering composure and cold judgment were both shield and hidden weapon.

But this was a first.

An opponent who did not fall to his sword, could not be stopped by his shield, and was untouched even by his hidden weapon. Someone who defied every judgment he had made.

How?

The Great Snow Fiend lifted his trembling eyelids and looked ahead.

FWOOSH.

The fierce snow wind subsided. Frost melted from the ground, and bitter heat mingled with the white breath spilling into the air.

At the center of it all stood one man.

Step.

Footsteps sounded in the silence. A figure emerged through the hazy steam, and the Great Snow Fiend saw a young man drenched in blood from head to toe.

In stark contrast, his eyes were clear and bright.

[2960] Ten thousand Korean geun is 6,000 kg, or about 13,200 lb. One geun is 600 g.

As the young man approached, the Great Snow Fiend pushed himself upright. Stone fragments pattered from his body, each one bringing a fresh stab of pain. He clenched his teeth, suppressed his internal injuries, and spat out a name.

"…Jin Taekyung."

His voice was as cold as his thoughts were muddled. Jin Taekyung's reply was perfectly calm.

"I'm surprised. I thought you wouldn't be able to move after that."

"What?"

"You've still got plenty of energy for an old man. But that's no good in a situation like this. It'll only make things more painful."

The Great Snow Fiend's eyebrow twitched as he realized something.

"…You."

"Oh, I don't mean anything by it. I think someone said something like that to me earlier, so I repeated it. Couldn't have been more than… fifteen minutes ago. Can't remember which fucking idiot was running his mouth, though."

"Early-onset dementia?" Jin muttered. He glanced over his shoulder and sighed. "Ah, this is going to keep me up tonight. That old man lying over there might know. Mind if I go ask him?"

"…!"

"I'll be right back, okay?"

It was utter nonsense. There was no asking a corpse with a crushed heart a question, much less getting an answer.

Blatant mockery, not worth listening to.

Yet the Great Snow Fiend bit his lip before he knew it. Normally, such drivel would not have drawn the slightest reaction from him. Now he could not help being shaken.

"Just what… are you?"

He genuinely wanted to know. How was Jin Taekyung still standing on his own two feet? Why had he not fallen with the Black Hand Fist Demon?

"I saw it with my own eyes. It was no illusion, no clumsy act. How… how did you do it?"

Every word was true.

Powerful Yin-Cold Qi had thrown Jin Taekyung's qi and blood into chaos, and the Force-wreathed twin wheels had cut him. That was why the Great Snow Fiend had remained certain until the final moment that his ice sword would kill both the wounded beast and the hunting dog.

Even his decision to kill the Black Hand Fist Demon had come from an experienced hunter's caution. There was no telling what a beast driven to the edge of a cliff might do.

But he had been wrong. No—everything had been turned upside down.

The hunter had failed to kill the beast. The beast had sunk its teeth into the hunting dog's neck and clawed the hunter's chest.

Something that could not happen, *should* not happen, had happened.

Jin Taekyung watched the Great Snow Fiend's uncomprehending face and murmured as if to himself.

"Yeah. Maybe it was."

The Great Snow Fiend could not know what he meant. It was a gamble only one person in this world could have made.

Level Up.

One move that could overturn an overwhelmingly unfavorable battle.

Jin Taekyung had staked everything on it. He had willingly offered up his flesh to make his enemies lower their guard, and at last he had taken their bones.

If the EXP from the Black Hand Fist Demon hadn't leveled me up… I'd be the one lying there.

But his gamble had paid off.

On the way to Ailao Mountain, he had fought more than ten battles. Breaking through the Poisonblood Grounds, he had killed hundreds of venomous beasts. Little by little, the EXP had accumulated.

Then he had added the Black Hand Fist Demon to it.

And I still had the ten points I got escaping the underground prison, plus the Fire Dragon Armor.

The Great Snow Fiend's unexpected move had left him with internal injuries first, but that had meant he could bring those advantages out at the moment they mattered most.

It had been close. The result was what counted.

The punch Jin Taekyung had thrown with every ounce of his strength had taken the Black Hand Fist Demon's life faster than the ice sword could, while the Great Snow Fiend's ice sword had failed to pierce the Fire Dragon Armor completely.

Jin Taekyung suddenly remembered something he had heard long ago from a man who loved Go. Every time the man lost a game, he would shout, "Japs out! Chinks out!"

"Son, there's a saying in Go: a large group doesn't die easily."

"Dad. Is that Buddhist?"

"No, no. A large group—a big formation of stones—is hard to kill."

"Oh, I see. But Dad, why did you lose this game?"

"Because the large group died… Honey! Please take Taekyung away! Honey!"

A quiet laugh escaped him.

His father had been right. A large group did not die easily.

After a run of bad moves, one brilliant move could make it larger than any other stone and give it command of the board.

Just like now.

“Black Hand’s already gone ahead. Time for our Santa Claus to go see his parents, too. Just so you know, I don’t offer people a chance to surrender.”

SHING.

In his blood-soaked hand, White Flame’s spearhead leveled at the Great Snow Fiend.

The old man stared back through bloodshot eyes.

“Do not spout nonsense. You have gained a slight advantage, nothing more. This is not over.”

Jin Taekyung did not bother arguing. At least the damned old man was right about one thing: it was not over.

Sacrifice flesh to break bone.

The flesh he had given up had served its purpose, but a single level-up had not been enough to heal his earlier internal injuries and the wounds left by the twin wheels.

And just as he had risen again after taking the first attack, the Great Snow Fiend still had plenty of strength left.

“You will die, and this old man will live. That is the natural order, the mandate granted by Heaven.”

FSSSSSH.

Cold spread around them with his icy voice.

Even a full-strength blow from the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist had not put the old monster down. Jin Taekyung roused the fire dragon filling his lower dantian once more.

“Well, I can understand an old man becoming senile…”

FWOOSH.

Blue-white flames spread over the transparent spearhead, driving back the cold. Fire rose in his faintly warm eyes.

“But if some bastard from Dark Heaven starts talking about Heaven’s mandate, you won’t even get to see your parents after you die.”

At that moment—

POP!

The space between them vanished. Flame and cold collided.

KWAANG!

The world shook. The fire spear and ice sword met with a tremendous roar.

A shock wave that seemed to shake earth and sky swept outward. The explosion hurled both figures back, but neither yielded an inch before stepping toward the other again.

SHWIK!

One step. That was all the Great Snow Fiend needed. He shot forward in an instant and flicked his blood-soaked sleeve.

BOOM!

Cold fierce enough to freeze the air swept over a thousand-geun[2961] boulder embedded deep in the ground.

A rock?

The Great Snow Fiend looked up the moment he understood.

Half a beat ahead of him, Jin Taekyung had stepped on empty air as though climbing an invisible stair. Now he was falling, body and spear as one.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear.

Second Form.

Heavenly Strike.

KRAAAAA!

There was no time to think. The Great Snow Fiend swung his ice sword upward on instinct.

A streak of flame descended like a meteor and struck the blade.

KWAANG!

Fifteen minutes earlier, he could have blocked it without difficulty. Not now.

With his internal energy fully restored, Jin Taekyung's attack was heavier and sharper than before. The Great Snow Fiend's own internal injuries were no small matter, either.

Hngh.

Blood surged into his mouth. He swallowed it with a groan and turned his ice sword, sending the flames sliding into the ground, where they exploded.

The deafening blast flung him backward. Through his spinning vision, he sent the ice sword shooting toward the figure ahead of him as though he had thrown it.

SHWAAK! KWAANG!

Jin Taekyung knocked aside the ice sword hurtling at him faster than sound. Without hesitating, he drove his foot against the rock frozen by Yin-Cold Qi.

FSSSH. KRRRUNCH.

The ice melted. Web-like cracks spread across the hard stone.

Then a streak of flame rose.

KRAAAAA!

[2961] A thousand Korean geun is 600 kg, or about 1,320 lb.

Flamefire Path.

Wrapped in blue-white fire, Jin Taekyung charged at the Great Snow Fiend—the old monster who dared defy the natural order while invoking Heaven's mandate.

I can do this.

It was neither certainty nor complacency. He simply trusted himself.

Holding his breath, he cut through the space between them, took the spear shaft in a reverse grip, and sent it forward.

SHWAAAAAAK!

The flame-wreathed spearhead grazed past in an instant. It split the wind. It burned the air.

And at the end of its path stood a man.

"Ha!"

Too fast.

With a roar, the Great Snow Fiend gathered Yin-Cold Qi in both hands. White Force that seemed capable of freezing the world itself shot toward the spearhead.

No. It *should* have.

SHWIK! SLASH!

Pain struck his back.

Something trailing white fur and leaving a burning sting flashed across his vision. It raced onward without slowing, while the old monster's judgment faltered.

Damn it. Baek…

The Great Snow Fiend swallowed the curse rising in his throat and thrust both palms with all his strength toward the blue-white hellfire filling his vision.

KWAAAAANG!

RRRRUMBLE!

A roar like the sky splitting apart shook the world.

Chapter 684

RRRUMBLE!

The earth shook with a thunderous roar.

Ancient trees whose roots had held for longer than anyone could guess. Boulders weighing ten thousand geun.[2962] Even the strange creatures of the Poisonblood Grounds that had been hiding somewhere, watching the battle with bated breath.

All were buried as the earth heaved and overturned like a wave.

KRRRUNCH!

It was hot.

At the center of the shock wave, I felt a scorching wind whip around me. There was not a trace of coolness in the muggy air, and the thick dust cloud covering dozens of jang[2963] left me unable to see a thing.

But I remembered clearly how the old man had driven both palms, packed with immense Yin-Cold Qi, toward the spearhead bearing down on him. I remembered the red blood gushing from his body, too, and the White Tiger's figure disappearing into the distance in a flurry of white fur.

That bastard…

Muyaho's sudden ambush on the Great Snow Fiend had not been planned. I had told him the opposite: stay out of the fight and find Yohi, who was probably being held captive somewhere in the Poisonblood Grounds.

Even if I died here today, I wanted that clever beast to get out alive. If he went to the Nanman Beast Palace with the two Great Chieftains, there would still be hope of preventing the disaster to come.

But Muyaho had ignored me, and his reckless, dangerous ambush had worked.

It was a tiny difference, but it was there. The unexpected attack slowed the Great Snow Fiend's reaction.

Sending White Flame flying—practically an extension of myself—had been worth it.

A wounded hunter who had lost his composure was no longer a hunter. He was prey.

Where are you?

POP!

I muttered the question and shot forward.

Thick dust swirled around me. Soil and stones rained down on every side. They blocked my sight and masked every presence, so I drove a fist through them.

[2962] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

[2963] A jang is ten cheok, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

BOOM!

I did not even need to put internal energy into it. My fist broke the sound barrier, and compressed air burst outward under the force of the blow.

The enormous dust cloud split in two, revealing what lay beyond.

FWOOSH!

Hot wind swept past me. The instant I glimpsed someone's blood-soaked clothes through the dust, I reached out without hesitation.

I had fought hard for this opening. Now that the balance was beginning to tip my way, I could not let it slip—even if it meant revealing abilities I had yet to show the Great Snow Fiend.

Inventory Open. Summon.

With the command in my mind, I hurled the spear that appeared in my hand with all my strength.

SHWAAAAK! BOOM!

It split the air and struck with a thunderous roar. Before the sounds had faded, another spear was in my hand.

SHWIK!

Again.

KWAANG!

And again.

More. More. More, more.

My body moved as fast as I could think. I twisted my waist, drew back my shoulder, and put my full weight behind each throw. The spears devastated everything around me like a bombardment.

RRRUMBLE!

I ignored the dust cloud as it began to rise again after briefly scattering.

I was pouring out attacks even more powerful than that.

Every spear was cheap iron, nothing compared to White Flame. But once I sent one flashing from my hand, no one it struck would come away unharmed.

Even a Supreme Peak master. No…

Not even the Great Snow Fiend.

BOOM! KWAANG! KRAAA-BOOM!

Explosions roared without pause. In a matter of moments, I drove more than ten spears into the earth like bolts of lightning.

Then I saw it.

KRRK! SPLAAASH!

Beyond the thick dust, bright-red blood scattered into the air to the grisly sound of torn flesh.

There you are.

Certain now, I stepped forward. The tip of my foot, bearing the weight of a thousand geun,[2964] dug deeply into the overturned earth.

KRRRUNCH. BOOM!

An explosion occurred at the same time as I compressed my internal energy. I surged forward, erasing more than ten jang[2965] of space in an instant, and plunged into the dust cloud.

The noise and falling debris had made it nearly impossible to tell front from back. But I did not hesitate.

I've already seen him.

My sharp senses detected the metallic scent of blood, and my keen eyesight once again found someone's back through the dust cloud.

The Great Snow Fiend had been injured blocking White Flame. He could not be faster than me now.

I summoned a spear from my Inventory and slashed it down diagonally.

SHIIING.

With a low sound of splitting air, blue-white flames rose around the spearhead and slowly cut through the wind.

But the spearhead was not the only thing that had slowed. Extreme concentration paralyzed my brain and brought the world to a standstill.

In that frozen moment, the flames parted the dust and touched the edge of the man's clothes. Certainty flashed through me.

It's over—!

Then why did I feel this inexplicable chill? This strange sense of déjà vu?

One more chi[2966] would end everything. Why was my body trying to retreat against my mind's command?

I understood at once. It was reason, but it was instinct too—instinct that had acted before reason could.

The Great Snow Fiend.

An old monster who had crawled out of the depths of a distant past. But what made him dangerous was not that he was a Supreme Peak master who had opened his Middle Dantian.

He possessed something the overwhelmingly powerful Blood Lord and Western Heaven Demon Lord had lacked—or had never felt any need for.

Caution. Thoroughness. Those were the old monster's sharpest weapons.

The Great Snow Fiend, this easy?

No. Not the Great Snow Fiend I had fought.

[2964] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

[2965] A jang is ten cheok, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[2966] A chi is approximately 3.03 cm (1.19 in).

In a fraction of an instant, I twisted with all my strength. My body stopped short, and the internal energy surging through me like a raging sea reversed course.

Hot blood welled up in my throat. My spearhead veered in midair and sliced through the clothes.

Then I saw it clearly.

SHNK.

In the slow-moving world, flesh and bone parted beneath the spearhead like tofu. Blood drifted upward as though weightless. Beyond it, disheveled hair fluttered, and over the shoulder of a corpse already dead, a pair of cold eyes gleamed.

I'll return it to you. Exactly the way you did.

I felt those words from a voice I could not hear.

Then a bitterly cold flash erupted from the gaping hole in the Black Hand Fist Demon's chest.

SHWAAASH!

I knew at once. I could not dodge this attack.

But I could avoid a fatal wound. Covering my upper body was Fire Dragon Armor, the extraordinary divine weapon I had gained by killing the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

But…

KRRUNCH! THUD!

Cold—and hot at the same time.

The Yin-Cold Qi seeping into my body. And the spearhead of another divine weapon, White Flame, which had broken through Fire Dragon Armor and lodged in my chest.

BEEP. BEEP. BEEEEP!

SYSTEM

- **Part of Fire Dragon Armor has been destroyed by powerful energy!**
- **Time remaining until Fire Dragon Armor is automatically repaired: 3 days**
- **Yin-Cold Qi is violently shaking your insides!**
- **Status abnormality: Bleeding**
- **Status abnormality: Massive Internal Injury**
- **There is a risk of qi deviation! Calm your energy as soon as possible!**
- **Your body has suffered severe internal and external damage!**

…

…

…

My vision grew hazy from the horrible pain. As warning sounds continued to pierce my ears without pause, I thought:

This was truly turning out to be one hell of a day.

Jin Taekyung was not the only one who felt the world stop in that instant.

Hidden in the dust, waiting for his final chance, the Great Snow Fiend felt it too. After the longest, hardest wait of his nearly century-long life, he could finally let out the breath he had been holding.

KRRUNCH. THUD!

A spearhead buried in a man's chest. A body trembling. Eyes filled with pain and despair.

"Gueeek!"

SPLASH!

Dark-red blood mixed with bits of organs splattered across the Great Snow Fiend's face.

The foul, bloody stench filled his nose, but it did not bother him. No, what stunned him was the sight of that young bastard still alive.

What a lunatic.

The Great Snow Fiend's plan would have been perfect if Jin Taekyung had not twisted away at the last moment. The spearhead meant for his heart had struck his chest instead.

And if this old man hadn't adjusted the thrust to follow him… it would only have caught his side.

A chill ran down the Great Snow Fiend's spine.

He had revised his assessment of Jin Taekyung long ago.

Not fifty years. Thirty. No—perhaps in twenty, he'll rival the Martial God and the Heavenly Demon.

A monstrous talent. A determination fiercer than fire.

It went beyond martial arts. It was strength that came from the man himself, an aura that inspired not merely wariness but fear.

In the Great Snow Fiend's eyes, Jin Taekyung was already strong enough to stand beside the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families. Even beside the Ten Kings, he would not fall short.

But this is as far as you go.

GRIND.

The Great Snow Fiend gritted his teeth and tightened his grip on the spear shaft.

His right sleeve hung empty, as though something had torn the arm from it. He had lost it to the White Tiger's ambush and the spear that had come crashing down immediately afterward. He had no regrets.

An arm was nearly as precious as his life, but Dark Heaven's uncanny sorcerers would surely find a solution without much difficulty.

What mattered now was that he could finish Jin Taekyung—that terrifyingly tenacious monster.

Did I not tell you? You will die, and this old man will live. That is the natural order. Heaven's mandate.

Fear and joy mingled on the Great Snow Fiend's face as he gathered the little strength he had left.

The cool shaft of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron drove deeper into Jin Taekyung's chest.

KRRUNCH!

The spearhead, wreathed in cold instead of flame, dug into its owner's chest. Flesh split, bone cracked, and Jin Taekyung's body jerked.

PFFT. SPLAAASH!

Blood spurted like a fountain. His eyes slowly dimmed.

The Great Snow Fiend had watched countless people die. He had never been more certain.

No one can save him now. Not the Divine Physician. Not even the Great Firmament Immortal.

But he had forgotten something.

The young man dying right before his eyes was an existence akin to supernatural powers—something that could not be predicted by his judgment.

GRAB. THRUST!

He had neither time nor strength to respond.

In his eyes, coldness gave way to shock. Reflected there was Jin Taekyung, gripping the spear shaft with all his strength and pushing himself forward, driving it deeper into his own chest.

And in his blood-soaked hand, the last flame burned.

"…!"

Blue-white light-flames spread across the Great Snow Fiend's widened eyes.

FWOOSH—KWAANG!

Chapter 685

FWOOSH. KWAANG!

Blue-white light-flames filled the Great Snow Fiend's vision.

An explosion sounded as though announcing the end of everything. His aged body flew through the air in an arc and slammed into a massive boulder, shattering it.

KRRRUNCH.

His blood-red vision grew hazy. The sounds reaching his ears seemed to come from hundreds of *li* away.[2967]

And yet his mind remained startlingly clear.

Like a candle burning brightest just before it went out.

A final rally.

The four characters flashed through the Great Snow Fiend's mind. At the same time, something hot rose in his throat.

COUGH.

Dark-red blood soaked his lower body. Bits of organs were mixed in with it. He stared blankly at the mess, then realized something.

No. He was certain.

This time, there could be no mistake.

It's over. All of it.

Strange as it was, pain was how people knew they were alive.

Yet even with the meridians throughout his body torn apart by Scorching Yang Qi, his flesh and bones crushed, the Great Snow Fiend felt no pain.

Only fear.

Fear of the death finally looming before him, and of the figure approaching through his blood-red vision.

"Jin… Taekyung."

The name escaped his trembling lips in something like a moan.

No answer came to the dying old man.

No—Jin Taekyung could not answer.

DRIP. DRIP.

Blood fell with every step he took. He staggered as though he might collapse, his eyes unfocused.

But he was alive.

With his beloved spear lodged near his ribs, Jin Taekyung was coming toward the Great Snow Fiend, fighting off even the death closing in on him.

How can this be…?

[2967] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

It was not just death or the cold that made the Great Snow Fiend tremble.

He was afraid. And he wanted to know.

They were made of the same flesh and blood. How was that young monster still standing? What had brought the two of them to this?

Where did it begin? What went wrong?

Nearly half a century had passed since he had left his family, subordinates, and friends behind and departed his homeland alone.

To overcome his limits, he had created new martial arts. He had risked death countless times and devoted his life to perfecting them.

The righteous path? He had never cared for that shallow phrase hypocrites liked to spout.

He had to survive, whatever it took. And if he was ever to return home, he had to become strong enough that no one could ignore him.

Without that single-minded purpose, he would never have taken the hand Dark Heaven offered him decades ago.

The day the Lord of Heaven descends upon this land, everything you desire will come true.

Everything…?

Yes. If that is what you want.

The Great Snow Fiend had believed those words. He had pledged himself to Dark Heaven. At the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's command, he had even taken on a successor—something he had never imagined doing—and taught him the martial arts he had created.

All while waiting for *that day*.

So why?

"Why should this old man—why should *I* die by your hand? Why!"

The Great Snow Fiend raised his head with that strangled cry and saw a pair of eyes still holding a flame that had not gone out.

A faint voice reached him.

"Because I have a reason."

What?

"A reason I have to survive, no matter what. A reason I sometimes have to risk dying."

"…!"

"That's the biggest difference between us."

Jin Taekyung reached out with a trembling hand. His blood-soaked fingers closed around the spear lodged in his chest.

SPLASH. DRIP, DRIP.

He drew the spearhead out slowly. Blood came with it, spattering across the Great Snow Fiend's face.

Jin Taekyung convulsed in agony, and the Great Snow Fiend laughed as though he had lost his mind.

"Follow me soon. I'll be waiting in the afterlife."

SWISH.

The wavering spearhead touched his throat. Jin Taekyung muttered, his voice worn thin.

"Idiot. Go find your parents."

And that was the end.

SHNK.

The cold blade pierced his throat.

In a moment that seemed to stretch on while everything else stood still, the Great Snow Fiend watched the world darken. It was nowhere near enough time to look back over the century he had lived.

Damn it.

The curse never left his lips. The old monster who had dominated an era fell into deep darkness.

No one survives a spearhead through the throat.

Not a Supreme Peak master with several jiazi[2968] of Yin-Cold Qi. Not a fiend who has lived nearly a century.

Just as it was now.

SHNK.

The transparent spearhead pierced his throat, and that was it.

The Supreme Peak master once known as the Great Snow Fiend was gone.

I stared blankly down at the corpse, its eyes wide open and its body frozen in place, then let out a short groan.

"…Ah."

It was over. Finally.

The moment I recognized reality along with the thought filling my mind, the world tilted.

SLIP.

No. *I* was tilting.

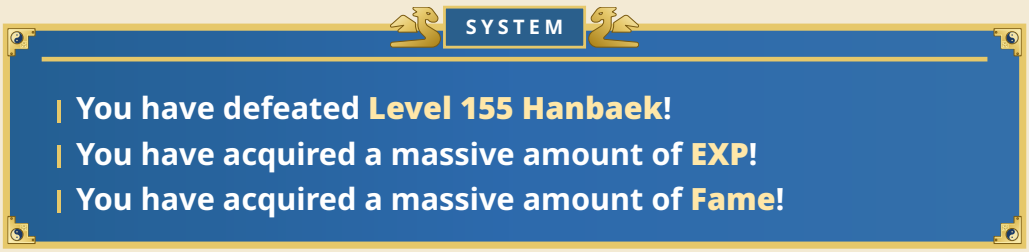
I tried to stay on my feet, but there was nothing I could do. The last scrap of strength left my hand, and the spear shaft slipped from my grip.

[2968] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

THUD.

My vision blurred. Pain, exhaustion, and relief—everything I had managed to forget for a moment—came crashing over me.

I collapsed where I stood and lay gasping, staring into the air.



That was all.

There were three numbers in the holographic window visible through my blurred vision. None of them announced a level-up, and the System remained silent.

And I…

This would be pretty lame if it were a hidden-camera prank.

I laughed at the stupid thought. There was no particular reason. The corners of my blood-crusted mouth lifted, and a hollow chuckle escaped.

Fuck. Hidden-camera prank, my ass.

Right. So that's how it is.

How long could I last like this?

Fifteen minutes? Seven and a half?

Should I just be glad Muyaho got away alive?

It was strange. My last hope had fallen apart, but I felt calm enough to surprise myself.

Maybe I had seen it coming, somewhere deep down.

Luck doesn't come twice in a row.

The level-up I had gained from killing the Black Hand Fist Demon had been a gamble in the first place. Without a way to see my exact EXP, I could only guess.

That should be enough to level up.

Or:

No. That won't do it.

Unfortunately, this time it was the latter.

The Great Snow Fiend had left behind a massive amount of EXP, just as the System said. But it was less than what I had earned on the way to the Poisonblood Grounds and from the Black Hand Fist Demon combined.

Or maybe my earlier stroke of luck had raised the amount I needed for the next level.

Either way, the conclusion was simple. My first gamble had paid off. My second hadn't.

As if Heaven had decided my fate from the start.

Damn fate.

Fate. I had hated that word for a long time.

It could mean something good, sure. But it was also two little characters you could use to lump together every fucked-up thing that happened in the world.

Some things in life were too cruel and hopeless to shrug off as fate.

Like the memory of a certain day I kept hidden in one corner of my heart.

"Um, Mr. Kim?"

"Oh! Yes, Vice Principal. What brings you here all of a sudden…?"

"Sorry to interrupt your class, but could we talk outside for a moment?"

Even now, I remembered it like a scene from a cheap black-and-white movie.

Scene one: The bald vice principal appeared, cleared his throat, and left with my homeroom teacher.

Scene two: Through the glass window in the classroom's front door, I watched my homeroom teacher's bewildered face slowly harden.

And scene three: After returning to the classroom, my homeroom teacher called out a student's name after a brief silence.

"Taekyung. Could you come outside for a moment?"

That was how I went from Extra Number One to the star of the movie.

No. I had never wanted to be the star. I wished it really had been a movie. Then I could have half-killed the screenwriter and director behind that shitty story until they called for another take.

But life is *one take*.

With every moment and every choice, the story flows with me at its center.

I had never given life a serious thought until I saw my father beneath a white sheet.

Cause: a Monster Wave. Cause of death: crushing.

That was when I understood. My father's story had ended because of that damn word, *fate*, and mine had begun.

"…COUGH."

SPLASH. DRIP, DRIP.

But I didn't want the last scene of my story to be me bleeding from my seven apertures[2969] on the cold ground.

No soft music over ending credits listing my family, friends, and comrades, either.

[2969]The seven apertures are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

I still had a chance to defy this damn fate. A third chance to put my life down as the stake before it burned to ash and scattered.

I want to live.

That single thought filled my head.

It was as simple as that. I didn't want to die here. There was too much I still had to do, too many people I had left behind.

CRUNCH.

I mustered what little strength remained and bit my tongue. The sharp pain brought my fading sight and mind back into focus, if only a little.

Now.

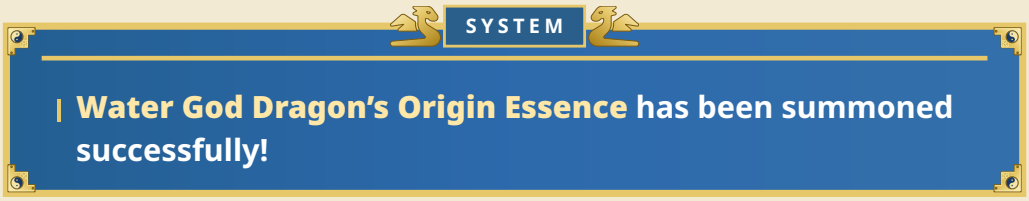
I opened my trembling hand and gave the command in my mind.

Inventory Open. Summon.

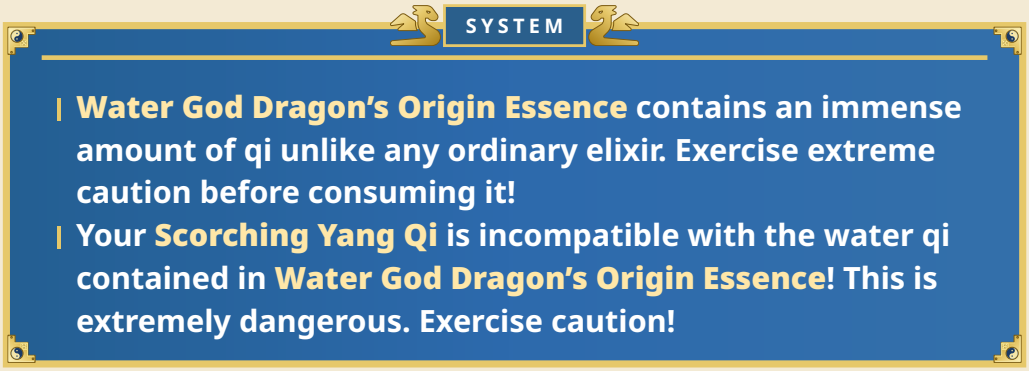
SWISH.

Something cool and smooth settled against my palm. At the same time, two very different System alerts sounded in my ear.

DING.



BEEP!



I knew. I knew this was insane.

What I was about to do went against the principles of Yin and Yang[2970] and the Five Elements[2971]—the foundation of most internal energy cultivation techniques.

Pouring water on fire. It was like trying to evolve Charmeleon into Blastoise.[2972]

But…

[2970] Yin and Yang are complementary forces in traditional Chinese thought.
[2971] The Five Elements are wood, fire, earth, metal, and water in traditional Chinese thought.
[2972] Charmeleon and Blastoise are Pokémon from different evolution lines.

There's no time.

To hell with incompatibility. Whether I bled to death in fifteen minutes or exploded because I couldn't contain the Origin Essence's power, I'd be dead either way.

At least the second option gave me a sliver of a chance.

GURK.

I spat up another surge of blood, squeezed out what little strength I had left, and pushed myself upright. Fighting through pain that made my body feel as though it were crumbling, I sat cross-legged and looked up at the sky.

Fuck, look at those storm clouds. Even the sky has to be dark as hell.

It was partly because it was nighttime, but no matter how I looked at it, this was a perfect day to hate dying.

No one was watching, and there wasn't even anyone to stick a cigarette in my mouth. Not that I'd smoke it if there were.

HAAH.

My trembling breath drifted away instead of cigarette smoke.

Night wasn't the only reason my briefly clear vision was darkening again.

I was dying. Quickly.

The moment for my final gamble was almost here.

Now.

I lifted my convulsing hand to my mouth and swallowed the blue pearl, filled with impossibly pure and dangerously vast qi.

Or I tried to.

Until cool qi suddenly swept in from somewhere and engulfed me.

FWOOSH!

What?

Every hair on my body seemed to stand on end. I froze like a statue, and one word flashed through my mind.

Enemy!

But it wasn't. Something had brushed past me, yet I was still alive. Then a thunderous roar in the distance drove the question from my mind.

"GRAAAAH!"

"…!"

I had been sure he'd escaped. I'd told myself to be glad at least he had survived.

You came back after all.

My sight was blurred, but the snow-white body shone bright enough to recognize even in the dark.

Nor was it difficult to make out the figures of two people sitting on the back of the White Tiger as it raced toward me like the wind.

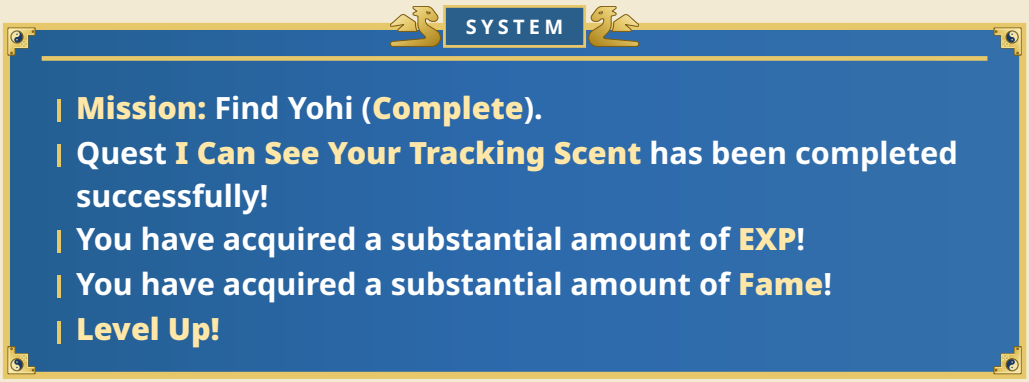
Heugung. And Yohi.

As their faces came into view, I remembered the Quest I had forgotten for a moment.

Then I stared blankly up at the sky and muttered:

“Just as I thought. It’s a perfect day to hate dying.”

DING.



I could feel it.

Death falling away from me. A gentle warmth wrapping around my wounded, exhausted body.

DING. DING. DING.

Clear bells rang beneath the storm-clouded sky. I slowly closed my eyes.

SLIP.

With no moonlight to be seen, the sleep demon came pouring down instead.

It was stronger than any enemy I had ever faced.

Chapter 686

Jin Taekyung fell into a sleep so deep it was almost unconsciousness. At nearly the same moment, Muyaho, who had been racing like the wind, stopped in his tracks.

THUMP.

Leaning against a shattered boulder, Jin's head drooped.

Yohi caught her breath. Heugung had climbed down from Muyaho's back a step ahead of her and was checking Jin's pulse. He let out a sigh.

"Whew. Fortunately, he's still alive."

It was good news, but Yohi's face did not brighten.

"*Still*?"

Only then did Heugung realize how his words had sounded.

"I misspoke in my haste. He's not at death's door. I don't think you need to worry too much."

"Not at death's door? Looking like that?"

Yohi had every reason to doubt him.

Jin Taekyung was drenched in blood from head to toe. His clothes were torn and slashed all over, and the unidentified armor covering his upper body was shattered at the chest, as though something had pierced it.

It was hard to believe he was alive at all.

Yet Heugung was telling the truth.

"I've examined him. His injuries aren't as serious as we might think. But these wounds… I can hardly believe what I'm seeing."

Although their internal energy had been sealed for the time being, both of them were martial artists who had reached the Peak realm.

The two Great Chieftains could not reconcile the wounds they saw with Jin's condition, but they breathed a sigh of relief when they realized his life was not in immediate danger.

That relief had barely settled when they noticed someone lodged in the massive boulder Jin was leaning against.

Yohi stifled a cry.

The unidentified old man was frozen there with his eyes wide open. He was already dead. Blood still flowed from his throat, pierced by a snow-white spearhead.

THUD. DRIP, DRIP.

Yohi stared at the old man, every bit as blood-soaked as Jin, and murmured, "That's him."

"Who?"

"The one who spoke to Black Hand as if that old man were his subordinate."

"Ah."

"And if I'm right…"

Yohi swept her gaze across the area. It stopped on the corpse of the Black Hand Fist Demon.

He had slaughtered the warriors of the Western Yao Estate with the prowess of a fiend. Now he lay dead with a gaping hole in his chest.

This is impossible.

Yohi's eyebrows trembled. She had begun to suspect it when she found the unidentified old man, but what had happened here went far beyond anything she had imagined.

She was not alone.

"How did he…"

Heugung swallowed the rest. It made no sense, but the scene before them was real.

The surroundings had been devastated by a force unlike anything they had seen. Two old men lay dead. One young man slept alone.

The conclusion was plain.

Jin Taekyung had fought and won—against two Supreme Peak masters who had devoted several times as many years to martial arts as he had been alive.

"…Blazing Flame Divine Dragon."

The sobriquet slipped from Yohi's red lips like a groan. Awe filled her eyes as she looked at Jin.

Whether it should have been possible no longer mattered. He had made it possible, willingly risking his life to save them, though they were only southern tribespeople to him.

Now it was their turn to act for him.

It may already be too late. But I have to act now.

Some of Nanman's venomous beasts shed their skins at certain times. They molted.

A new body did not come easily. Succeed, and the creature emerged more beautiful and stronger. Fail, and it slowly died in its old, ailing body.

Yohi chose the first path.

If I wait any longer, it'll all be over. I have to tell everyone what happened.

They had to expose Baeksang's conspiracy and stop Dark Heaven. Her own wrongdoing would come to light along with it, but she had made up her mind. She would bear the full cost of the path she had chosen.

I never should have done it.

Looking back, she felt nothing but regret.

Baeksang had laid a broad, beautiful road of silk before her. Yohi had walked it all the way here, turning a blind eye to everything happening around her.

But when she reached the end and happened to look down, she saw that her feet had long since become covered in blood.

Not her own. The blood of other Nanman people.

Now she wanted to wipe it away. If she could not, she would cut off her feet.

One person, more than any other, had brought her to that decision.

Jin Taekyung.

A stranger from a foreign land. Yet he had fought for Nanman more than anyone—just as the former Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan had done centuries ago, before he passed into legend.

I may be a Great Chieftain, but I can't be worse than a Han Chinese person.

If a bitch like me can even call herself a Great Chieftain…

Yohi swallowed the self-mocking words and immediately sprang into action.

RRRIP.

Without a moment's hesitation, her slender white hands tore at her ornate gown. She removed her gold and silver jewelry as well, baring her arms and legs.

Heugung's eyes widened.

"Yohi."

"There's no time to talk. We need to move now."

Heugung studied her in silence for a moment, then nodded.

"You're right. More enemies could arrive at any time."

"Considering how quiet it's been around us until now, it's safe to assume there aren't any others. No, they probably decided Dark Heaven didn't need to send more support after arranging for two Supreme Peak masters to come here."

"Probably. They knew about the tracking scent you carried. They must have meant to use us as bait to draw in Palace Lord Yayul. He would be Dark Heaven's greatest obstacle right now."

But Jin Taekyung, not the Beast Miao King, had taken the bait. The hunters had become the hunted.

No one, not even Dark Heaven, could have predicted that.

The longer they talked, though, the heavier Yohi's heart grew.

"What if Jin Taekyung didn't come in the Palace Lord's place? What if the Palace Lord *couldn't* come?"

"That…"

"My tribespeople were massacred. The Western Yao Estate. Nothing like this has ever happened before. The Inner Palace must be in an uproar by now."

"Then shouldn't we go to the Inner Palace as quickly as possible?"

Yohi shook her head. She had shut her eyes and ears for the sake of her ambitions, but she was no fool.

Dark Heaven had won over Baeksang, the Beast Miao King's sworn younger brother, then waited decades for the right moment.

She remembered what the unidentified old man now buried in the boulder had said.

> "If you act rashly when the grand plan is so close, I will not forgive you."

The grand plan.

Yohi sensed indescribable danger and anxiety in those two words. She also realized that their abduction had been a carefully calculated act.

The Western Yao Estate, massacred. The Inner Palace, surely in chaos. Baeksang, with a base of support equal to—or greater than—the Palace Lord's.

And Dark Heaven had planned it all.

The answer was not hard to find.

"Yohi?"

Heugung's voice snapped her out of her thoughts. She bit her lip.

If the thought that just crossed my mind is correct…

The Inner Palace would be a demon-slaying battleground now, full of fiends and sinister schemes.

"We shouldn't go to the Inner Palace. We have to go west."

"West? Do you mean…"

"Yes. Boshan."

The tribes lived throughout Nanman, but each had a home base. Several thousand Yao people had settled in Boshan alone.

"Baeksang and Dark Heaven will have taken control of the Inner Palace by now. If the tribal chieftains and the Tribal Grand Council have made their decision, even the Palace Lord may be powerless to stop them."

"Hmm."

"Believe me. If we head to the Inner Palace now, we'll be eliminated before we even manage to enter it."

Heugung looked at her, his eyes grave.

"And if we go to Boshan?"

"I'm the Great Chieftain of the Yao people. Do I need to say more?"

"How many warriors can you muster?"

"A thousand, if I gather everyone I can. Nowhere near enough to face Baeksang with Dark Heaven behind him. But will his people still follow him once they know what's happened?"

"Public support will waver. His warriors will desert him."

“I’ll send messenger pigeons and messengers to every tribe and village. Seven days at most. Within that time, all of Nanman will know about Baeksang’s atrocities.”

Heugung let out a quiet exclamation as Yohi continued speaking without hesitation.

“You’re clever indeed. More so than the woman I thought I knew.”

For a moment, Yohi forgot their situation and gave a short laugh.

“That sounds strange coming from you. You’ve become a completely different person.”

“I had no choice. To escape Baeksang’s notice, I first had to hide who I was.”

Heugung answered calmly and held something out to her: a round pill wrapped in yellow paper.

“Take it.”

“What is it?”

“An antidote the Black Hand Fist Demon was carrying. I found it when I searched him a little while ago. With our internal energy sealed, Baeksang’s warriors will hunt us down before we reach Boshan.”

He was right. No matter how skilled a warrior might be, without training in external arts they could not shake off a pursuit party. Yohi’s martial prowess was not especially great to begin with.

RUSTLE.

She took the pill without protest, chewed it, and swallowed. The bitter taste made her wince, but it was a hundred times better than dying without even putting up a fight.

“How long will it take to reach Boshan?”

“We’re in Ailao Mountain, so… three or four days should be enough. First we have to get out of the Poisonblood Grounds.”

On the way in, they had seen venomous beasts unlike any they knew and a swamp of deadly poison. They knew where they were.

“Jin should be awake by then.”

“Yes. If he wakes, he’ll be worth an army.”

Heugung slung Jin over his back. Muyaho, who had been pissing on the dead Black Hand Fist Demon’s face, ran over and offered his back.

“Grrr.”

Heugung gazed at the White Tiger’s blue-white eyes.

“Don’t you find him strange?”

“What?”

“This one the Young Palace Lord keeps. Whenever I saw him in the Inner Palace, he bared his teeth at me. But with Jin Taekyung here, he’s gentle as a lamb.”

“He must have taken a liking to Jin. They say spiritual creatures know what sort of person they’re dealing with.”

Yohi answered without thinking. Then something struck her as odd.

Heugung gave a quiet laugh.

“Yes. I think you’re right.”

CRUNCH! THUD.

Blood sprayed, and the enormous silver body tipped sideways.

As Yohi stared blankly at the sight, Heugung’s voice reached her ears.

“Didn’t I tell you? I had to hide myself first.”

Chapter 687

SLICE. THUD!

For a moment, the world seemed to stop.

“Grrrk.”

The massive White Tiger lay panting where it had fallen, like a rotten log. Jin Taekyung was completely unconscious.

In Yohi’s eyes, one man held him in his arms and went on speaking calmly.

“I told you. I should have hidden myself first.”

“…!”

Enlightenment and shock flashed through Yohi’s mind like lightning. Her eyes, usually calm and deep, widened.

“Heugung, you—”

“You don’t call me big brother anymore. I rather liked hearing it.”

She had called him that until just a few shichen[2973] ago. But she could never call him that again.

The kindly, heavyset middle-aged man before her was not the Heugung she knew.

“Why?”

Heugung shrugged at the question in her voice. “It’s simple. Just as you used me, I used you.”

“…So you were working with Baeksang after all. You too.”

“That’s a strange way to put it. Weren’t we all working together?”

“…!”

Yohi went rigid. Heugung gave a short laugh.

“Don’t deny it. No one watched you and Baeksang more closely than I did.”

“Then your sudden visit to the Western Yao Estate…”

“All part of the plan. You, Jin Taekyung, the Beast Miao King—even Baeksang. Of course, none of you knew who I really was… Come to think of it, saying we were all working together is rather funny.”

Yohi swallowed a groan. She could understand why *she* had not known. Though she had sided with Baeksang, her part in it had gone no further than looking the other way.

But the fact that he had hidden his identity even from Baeksang meant…

“You’ve been watching us all this time. Baeksang and me.”

“Congratulations. One step closer to the answer. Two more to go.”

“On the Demon Empress’s orders?”

“Good. One last step.”

[2973] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours.

“You were the knife she kept hidden up her sleeve in case something went wrong.”

Clap. Clap.

Heugung slowly clapped his hands and smiled.

“Clever. That’s right. Though even I never dreamed things would go this far.”

Heugung slowly looked around. The entire area had been reduced to ruins. His gaze passed over the two dead old monsters before finally coming to rest on one person.

“Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. The Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and the heir of the Fire King who will one day inherit the orthodox lineage of the Fire Gate Clan.”

His voice was low. A strange glint crossed his eyes as he stared at Jin, who lay unconscious in his arms.

“When I found him here, I knew something had gone wrong. If everything had gone according to plan, he’d have been locked in the underground prison, or the Demon Empress would already have taken him. But…”

Jin Taekyung had followed the tracking scent to the Poisonblood Grounds. There, he had killed the two Supreme Peak masters the Demon Empress had stationed to await the Beast Miao King—and survived.

“Fools. She told them to be careful.”

Heugung muttered under his breath and spat out a wad of phlegm. Then he turned back to Yohi with his usual friendly smile, as if nothing had happened.

“I don’t know if capturing him alive is still the right choice, given how things have turned out… Still, I’m glad I can set things right. Ah, but first I should tell you our destination has changed.”

“…The Inner Palace. You’re taking us to the Inner Palace.”

Heugung nodded at her strained whisper.

“If I return, things should get interesting. The testimony of a Great Chieftain who survived a Han Chinese plot will throw Nanman into turmoil. Every warrior and beast in this land will gather at the Inner Palace, ready to fight the Central Plains.”

“But people aren’t fools. They’ll wonder how a man who’s only at the Peak realm escaped a deadly place like this on his own.”

“Not bad. But what if I were a Supreme Peak master?”

“What are you talking about…?”

“A Supreme Peak master believed to be strong enough to subdue Jin Taekyung. A man with the goodwill and standing to win over even those who would never side with Baeksang. Wouldn’t everyone believe him?”

Yohi froze.

“You… Don’t tell me—”

“That’s right.”

Heugung smiled and summoned his internal energy. From the Western Yao Estate until now, it had never once been sealed. It shifted his bones and flesh and twisted his muscles.

CRACK. CRACK.

The eerie sounds of flesh being torn apart pierced Yohi's ears.

Faint moonlight broke through the clouds. Beneath it, Heugung's shadow changed, growing taller and more powerfully built.

"Ghk."

With one last pained groan, the changes ended. A short title slipped from Yohi's frozen lips.

"…Palace Lord?"

She stared at the man before her in disbelief.

He was Heugung, yet he was the Beast Miao King. The Beast Miao King, yet unmistakably Heugung. He studied his enlarged shadow with a satisfied smile.

"People think the Bone-Shrinking Technique can only make a person smaller. But master it to Great Completion, and you can become someone else entirely."

"…!"

"Now, here's what we'll do. I—or rather, the Beast Miao King—came here and subdued Jin Taekyung. You survived his wicked plot and returned to the Inner Palace to tell everyone this."

He went on slowly as Yohi stared at him, stunned.

"That everything that has happened recently was a conspiracy by Jin Taekyung and the Murim Alliance to swallow Nanman whole. That we must mobilize every human and beast in this land, regardless of age or sex, and invade the Central Plains. What do you think?"

Yohi did not answer. She could not. Fear and rage seemed to squeeze the breath from her body, and the world swam before her eyes.

"H-How could you…"

"Ah. I forgot to mention one thing. Refuse, and Boshan will run red with blood. The four great tribes that rule Nanman will become three."

CRUNCH.

A thin line of blood trickled between Yohi's red lips as she struggled to contain her rage. She glared at Heugung, her eyes blazing, and spat out the words.

"You son of a bitch."

"You wound me. Is that any way to speak to your future husband?"

"Shut your mouth. Who said I was going to marry you?"

"You probably will, once you've watched more than five thousand Yao people lose their heads, one after another, before your eyes."

"…!"

“You’re a stubborn woman, and I’m a patient man. So I’ll wait until all five thousand heads have hit the ground.”

Heugung spoke without a hint of hurry. Then he beamed at Yohi as brightly as he always had, as though nothing had happened.

“I love you, Yohi.”

A chill swept through her, making every hair stand on end. She squeezed her eyes shut.

She could scarcely believe it: a plan that had been unfolding for who knew how long, and the true face of the wastrel everyone had dismissed.

The dark shadow of Dark Heaven hanging over her head.

Haa.

She breathed out, thoughts racing through her mind. Then she opened her eyes, drew the flexible sword at her waist, and spoke.

“You filthy traitor.”

“Filthy traitor? Please don’t be so hard on yourself.”

“I won’t deny it. I became a traitor too. But do you think Dark Heaven—the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—will let you live? What about the Yi people you lead?”

Her words rang out sharp and clear. Heugung blinked, then burst into hearty laughter.

“That has nothing to do with me.”

“What?”

“Some forty years ago, the former chieftain of the Yi people died in the Great Faction War. His only legitimate son left in Nanman was six years old. The able-bodied men and women had gone to war. His mother died before she ever saw his face. All he had beside him was an old nurse whose sight and hearing were failing.”

“…!”

“Yohi.”

Heugung—or rather, the man who had become Heugung—continued with a faint smile.

“I was never a traitor. Not for a single moment.”

CLANG.

The flexible sword slipped from Yohi’s grasp and struck the ground with a clatter.

Breathing hard, she tried to pick it up, but her body would not obey.

What is this?

Her eyelids trembled. Was the shock of everything she had learned making her freeze?

No. She could not move because a sinister, clinging qi had already spread through her entire body.

"Y-You…"

Her voice weakened, and her vision began to fade. Heugung's approaching figure wavered like a heat haze. His voice seemed to come from far away.

"This is why I can't help loving you. So breathtakingly beautiful, and so innocent too."

"That… wasn't an antidote…"

"Unfortunately, I'm not the Beast Miao King. Even crossing swords with you would be more than I could manage. Please forgive this sorry husband of yours, my dear wife. When you wake, I hope you'll make the choice that's best for everyone."

Yohi wanted to scream for someone to come and kill this horrible man. To pull them out of this dark pit and stop the vast scheme that threatened to swallow Nanman.

But the scream that rose in her throat never escaped her lips. And Jin Taekyung, seized by the monster known as the sleep demon, did not open his eyes until the very end.

Then—

SWISH. THUD.

Yohi collapsed like a puppet with its strings cut. Heugung caught her gently in his arms.

A smile appeared at the corner of his mouth, which now wore the face of the Beast Miao King.

"Even asleep, you're beautiful."

Heugung truly loved Yohi. It did not matter that she did not want him.

She would make the right choice eventually. In time, she would come to love him.

Dark Heaven—the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—would keep her promise. After all the years he had spent hiding who he was, his reward would be tenfold, twentyfold.

But first…

I need to finish this.

He kissed Yohi on the forehead and slowly turned.

He walked toward the culprit who had dared to jeopardize the grand plan.

Jin Taekyung.

No one had anticipated him. His appearance had dealt a severe blow to a plan on the verge of success. Two Supreme Peak masters, either of whom could turn the tide of a battle, had been lost.

But nothing had changed.

The grand plan will succeed. There are still others to take their place.

Jin Taekyung would not wake for at least several days. Once Heugung brought him and Yohi back to the Inner Palace, it would all be over.

Yes. Over.

He smiled in satisfaction, passed the panting White Tiger, and grabbed Jin Taekyung by the nape to lift him up.

He was about to lift him when—

Whoooooosh.

A chill wind blew in from somewhere. Heugung looked up.

In the pale moonlight, he saw the shape of something.

“What is that…?”

Before he could finish the question—

SHWAAAASH!

The bleak wind turned into a blade and engulfed his entire body.

Chapter 688

Baeksang stood alone before a mirror.

The mirror Southern Heaven Demon Empress had given him was large enough to reflect his entire body, unlike an ordinary one. Its surface was smooth, without a single scratch. Even in the Central Plains, let alone Nanman, a mirror of such quality would be hard to find.

But Baeksang looked into it for one reason alone: in his reflection, he could see the face of the son who looked just like him.

This has never happened before.

For more than forty years, he had steadied himself whenever he wavered. He had done it countless times to reach this position. Yet now he was more shaken than ever.

That must mean the grand plan I've spent decades carrying out is nearing its end.

A door opened behind him, and a familiar face appeared. Baeksang met the Captain of the Guards' eyes in the mirror.

"Have you brought him?"

The Captain hesitated at the sight of his lord standing lost in thought, then answered.

"He's on his way."

"Then why are you here?"

"An urgent report."

"An urgent report…"

Baeksang let the words trail off and crooked a finger. The Captain approached and lowered his voice.

"Last night, a massive wildfire was spotted three hundred li[2974] to the north."

"Ailao Mountain."

"Yes."

"Jin Taekyung must have started it."

"We need to confirm that, but given everything that's happened, he's the most likely culprit."

"It was Jin Taekyung. Once again, it seems glory-blinded moths have rushed toward the flames."

"The small and midsized tribes near Ailao Mountain joined forces, or so we're told. They attacked him with five hundred warriors and a hundred beasts, but…"

Baeksang waved him silent. He had heard enough. Five hundred stragglers hastily gathered together could do nothing to Jin Taekyung.

[2974] A Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi). Three hundred li are about 150 km (93 mi); a hundred li are about 50 km (31 mi).

The saying *the few cannot overcome the many* meant different things depending on who the opponent was. Jin Taekyung clearly lay outside the equation.

"I can guess how that ended. What happened to Jin Taekyung afterward?"

"They say he routed the warriors, then headed toward Ailao Mountain alone."

"He must have a purpose. The Poisonblood Grounds, perhaps?"

"The fire was too fierce for anyone to confirm where he went. It started at the mountain's entrance and has already spread halfway up."

"He means to see this through."

Ailao Mountain was among the most forbidding mountains in Nanman. Its slopes were treacherous, its valleys deep. Winding ridges stretched for a hundred li[2975] beneath a seemingly endless cover of ancient trees.

Now that a wildfire had settled over Ailao Mountain, it would take at least three full days and nights before there was even a sign of the flames dying down.

The whole mountain might burn.

If it was a coincidence, it was a remarkable one. Fire had not swept through Ailao Mountain in over two hundred years. The last time it had, someone from the Fire Gate Clan had used the entire mountain for kindling to destroy the Five Poisons Sect.

That was how Nanman found peace again.

But would it happen that way this time?

Baeksang studied his reflection in silence, then spoke.

"Evacuate every tribesperson living nearby. Choose three thousand capable warriors and blockade Ailao Mountain."

The Captain of the Guards had continued his report impassively, but a flicker of agitation crossed his face.

"Three thousand? When we've already ordered a general mobilization across Nanman?"

"We need to hold Jin Taekyung there, if only as a precaution."

"But my lord, even with that many men, we can't surround the entire mountain…"

"For all its size, Ailao Mountain has few passable entrances. Deploy them accordingly."

After a moment's thought, the Captain bowed his head.

"As you command."

"What of the other chieftains?"

"As I reported, five chieftains have disappeared. So have the warriors under the two chieftains who set out earlier with the scouting party."

"So it comes to this. They refuse to accept reality."

[2975] A Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi). Three hundred li are about 150 km (93 mi); a hundred li are about 50 km (31 mi).

Baeksang's voice was calm.

The missing chieftains were the ones who had never switched sides. Their loyalty to the Beast Miao King had held firm. Some had even spat at Baeksang when he tried to win them over.

"My lord, they've undoubtedly betrayed us. It isn't too late to send men after them __"

Baeksang shook his head.

"Someone told me not long ago that one diseased tree does not make an entire forest sick. We need only thin out the afflicted trees."

"You mean…"

"Thirty-two tribes have shared this land for centuries. I've often wondered how much longer that arrangement ought to last."

The Captain's eyes widened as he grasped his meaning.

"Thirty-two is too many to bring together behind one purpose," Baeksang continued, his voice low. "It's time to thin out the diseased trees and put the forest in order."

Expulsion. Or elimination.

The will of the man who had driven out this land's longtime ruler and taken his throne was unmistakable.

The Captain stared at his lord, mouth open, before asking, "What should we do?"

"If they leave, let them. Should they return home and rally their warriors, we'll have both a justification and the strength to act."

The Captain knew the balance of power had tipped long ago. But one man still worried him.

"If the Palace Lord—no, if Yayul Cheok joins them, it won't be so simple."

Baeksang regarded him for a moment.

"Long ago, while I was staying in the Central Plains, I heard an interesting story."

"My lord?"

"A monkey was born from stone. Its nature was so fierce, and its strength so great, that Shakyamuni, whom the monks of the Central Plains revere, offered it a wager: could it escape the palm of his hand?"

His calm voice held the Captain's attention.

"The monkey snorted and accepted. It rode a cloud to the edge of the world and even scribbled on five pillars it found there. Only when it returned did it learn that those pillars had been Shakyamuni's fingers."

Baeksang slowly opened his hand toward the mirror.

The enormous Palace Lord's Hall seemed to fit in his palm. Sky and river, earth and mountain—even if the mirror had shown all of Nanman, it would have fit there too.

“Yayul Cheok is no different. Now that I hold this position, he can never escape.”

“Then…”

“We have word that he went east. Take a thousand Bai warriors and pursue him yourself.”

“As you command.”

The Captain bowed, then moved his lips again.

“I beg your pardon, but we’re dealing with the Beast Miao King. As a precaution, perhaps you should deploy the Baekcheon Unit.”

Baeksang silently shook his head. The Baekcheon Unit was the blade he had secretly honed for decades.

He had to draw and wield it when it was most needed.

“That will be all. Our guest has arrived. You may go.”

He was speaking to the Captain, but his gaze—fixed on the mirror throughout their conversation—had found the old man standing in the open doorway.

“Then I’ll take my leave.”

After confirming that the Captain of the Guards had left the Palace Lord’s Hall, Baeksang slowly turned around.

“You’ve come, Head Elder.”

The greeting was matter-of-fact. The answer was not.

“Shut that filthy mouth of yours.”

THUD.

An old man approached, leaning on a cane. Age spots covered his face, and every patch of exposed skin was wrinkled. Anger burned in the corners of his eyes, where fluid had gathered.

“You wretched bastard.”

“I see you overheard us.”

“Do you think this old man doesn’t know what’s in your black heart? You meant for me to hear, didn’t you?”

“If you mean what I said about Yayul Cheok—the villain who defied the Tribal Grand Council to save a murderer, then betrayed the Nanman Beast Palace—yes.”

“You bastard!”

WHOOSH! CLACK.

The old man swung his cane with all his strength. Baeksang caught it in one hand.

There was little force behind the blow, and no internal energy to speak of.

Baeksang took the cane from him with ease, then flicked his sleeve. Invisible qi forced the old man down into a seat.

“You’ve aged since I last saw you. Your temper hasn’t changed, though.”

The old man trembled.

"If I'd known you would do this, I'd have beaten you to death with my own hands long ago."

"But far too much time has passed for that. Yayul Cheok has betrayed the Palace and fled. The fate of the Miao people now rests with a boy you once caught stealing fruit wine and scolded soundly."

"…!"

"It's time to leave the distant past behind and think about what comes next. With the Chieftain and Lesser Chieftain gone, everything depends on the choice you make as Great Chieftain of the Miao people."

The old man—the Miao Head Elder—glared at Baeksang for a long moment.

"So you've seized Nanman after all. Such ugly greed."

"Call it what you like. There's nothing I won't do to obtain what I so desperately want."

"You're Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace now. What more could you want? Do you mean to get your hands on the Beast King Stone and become a god?"

Baeksang shook his head.

"I have no interest in some ancient sacred treasure passed down only by word of mouth. What I want now is the future—and your wise choice, Head Elder."

"The boy I remember wasn't like this."

"I changed. Everything does."

"The Palace Lord trusted you. Even though I told him to be so wary, he trusted his one and only sworn brother."

"Not every act of trust needs to be repaid."

"It isn't too late. Even now—"

"I crossed that river long ago. Once you're on a tiger's back, you can't climb down. Now it's your turn to get on, Head Elder."

CRACK.

Bones shifted in the old man's tightly clenched fist.

"So that's what you want from this old man. You want me to betray the Palace Lord?"

"Of course not."

Baeksang picked up his teacup.

"I want all the Miao people to betray him. You included."

"…!"

"Read the situation carefully, if you want to save more than ten thousand of your people."

"You bastard!"

"Remember: this is my first and last offer."

Baeksang tilted the teacup.

The Head Elder squeezed his eyes shut.

After a short silence, his hoarse voice broke through.

“Impossible.”

CLACK.

Baeksang set down the teacup and stared at the Head Elder with deeply sunken eyes.

“Won’t you regret that answer?”

“Kill me instead. Ask any Miao person, and you’ll hear the same answer.”

“You haven’t disappointed me.”

Baeksang snapped his fingers. The closed door opened, revealing Bai warriors.

“Lock up the entire Miao leadership in the underground prison, including the Head Elder.”

The warriors bowed, took the Head Elder by either arm, and pulled him to his feet.

The old man, whose day of death was approaching, cried out in a ringing voice.

“Baeksang! You bastard! Aren’t you afraid of Heaven?”

By the time his scream had gradually faded into the distance, Baeksang was looking down at the empty teacup and muttering.

“What more is there to fear? Heaven’s will brought me this far.”

There had been a time when he resented Heaven.

After the Great Faction War ended and he returned to Nanman, Baeksang spent every day drunk. He drank as though each day were his last, then despaired when the next morning’s sunlight woke him.

Why did you let me live? Why?

Those days had been more painful than death.

But he could not spend forever writhing in grief. There was something he had to do.

Something he *had* to do.

Baeksang looked through the window at the blue sky.

Is this truly your will? No… Have you ever watched over me even once?

As always, he waited in vain for an answer.

Except for the unfamiliar voice that pierced his ears the next moment.

“Um… Shall I refill your tea?”

Baeksang turned toward it.

A pretty maid stood at the half-open door, looking at him.

“No need.”

“But your cup is empty.”

“I said there’s no—”

He stopped. After studying the maid for a moment, he said, “Come in.”

At his quiet command, the warriors who had moved to stop her stepped back. The door closed firmly behind her.

She hurried over in small steps and slowly tilted the teapot above his cup.

Trickle.

Steam rose, carrying the scent of tea. Yet Baeksang felt a throb of pain, as though he had inhaled Poison Mist.

Baeksang silently watched the teacup fill before suddenly speaking.

“Whose face is that, Demon Empress?”

The maid—Southern Heaven Demon Empress—smiled.

“A girl who worked in the Inner Palace. So young and fresh. She was too cute to resist.”

“Did you kill her?”

“Oh my. Does that matter so much?”

“That…”

“How interesting. Hundreds of people have already died, and you are worried about the life of one maid.”

Baeksang fell silent, then answered evenly.

“I only asked because it might disrupt the plan. Anything that happens in the Inner Palace is quickly discovered.”

“Ah, I see. Well, if that’s your concern…”

Southern Heaven Demon Empress gave him a coy smile and picked up the teacup.

“You needn’t worry about that. If there’s a problem, it’s at Ailao Mountain, not the Inner Palace.”

“Ailao Mountain? Do you mean…?”

“Yes. Jin Taekyung. That child has done something. We still haven’t heard from them, so I’m sure of it.”

Baeksang thought for a moment.

“It was a trap?”

“That’s right. A trap laid to catch the old tiger who had left the Palace. I never expected the young tiger to get caught in it instead.”

CLICK.

She set down her cup, amusement in her voice.

“Of course, I didn’t expect the young tiger to be strong enough to break it, either.”

“It must have been a thorough trap, for you to be so confident in it.”

“Two Supreme Peak masters. One was the Black Hand Fist Demon. The other…”

She paused and smiled at Baeksang.

“At any rate, he was strong. Far stronger than the Black Hand Fist Demon.”

“…!”

“It is astonishing. I thought those two would be able to deal with the Beast Miao King. It seems the Lord of Heaven was not interested in that child for no reason.”

For Baeksang, each revelation was more startling than the last. Jin Taekyung had not only killed two Supreme Peak masters single-handedly—the Lord of Heaven himself was also interested in him.

Baeksang also realized his own judgment had been sound.

Jin Taekyung.

The young man’s face came to mind. Baeksang had never been able to get a firm measure of him.

He looked at the smiling Demon Empress.

“You’ll take action yourself now.”

A Supreme Peak master was a formidable asset. With two of them dead, Baeksang thought her intervention inevitable.

At least, that was what he thought until he heard her answer the next moment.

“No? Why would I?”

She let out a short laugh.

“I do not have time to worry about that. Even if one of the major pieces has died, the current situation will not be overturned. What matters is the grand plan.”

“You mean…?”

“The Beast Miao King and Jin Taekyung no longer matter. Secure the Inner Palace and Outer Palace. Gather every force you have.”

Southern Heaven Demon Empress rose and crossed the room almost as though she were dancing. Her voice rang with delight.

“Three days. No more than three days.”

“…!”

“Be ready. That day, everything will begin—and end.”

THUD.

The door opened and closed.

Long afterward, Baeksang remained where he was, frozen.

That day was coming.

The day he had longed for more than anyone in the world—and feared more than anyone.

Chapter 689

Drip. Drip.

Cold.

That was Yohi's first thought when she opened her eyes.

She stared blankly at the drops falling onto her forehead. Then memories she had briefly forgotten began to return, one by one.

This is…

She remembered who she was. The life she had lived. What had happened at the Western Yao Estate, and what she had seen in the Poisonblood Grounds.

And…

I love you, Yohi.

The face and voice of that man made her shudder even now. Behind him lay a massive White Tiger and a young man.

All of it—

"Gasp…!"

Yohi shot upright, barely swallowing the scream about to burst from her lips.

With everything that had happened before she collapsed rushing back to her, she looked around in fear.

Where am I?

She did not recognize the place. Darkness blurred its outlines, and silence lay all around her. There was too little light to make anything out clearly, but she could tell she was enclosed on every side.

As though someone had prepared a prison for her.

Heugung.

No. The man who had stolen Heugung's name.

At the thought of the man whose entire life had been a lie, Yohi instinctively reached for her waist. She always wore her flexible sword wrapped around it like a sash, ready for an emergency. But her hand found only silk soaked with blood and dirt.

Ah. That's right.

She remembered losing her flexible sword after being drugged by an unidentified substance.

She had never taken the antidote, so naturally, her internal energy would still be sealed…

"Huh?"

The sound slipped out before she could stop it. Yohi clapped a hand over her mouth, though her wide eyes gave away her surprise.

How?

She forced herself to calm down and checked her body again. Then a third time.

There was no mistaking it.

The seal on my internal energy… It's gone.

She could feel the internal energy she had built up through countless elixirs filling her lower dantian.

But why? And how?

Heugung should have captured all of us.

She could make no sense of it. Why was she alone in this enclosed space? Why had the seal been lifted?

At the end, no one had been able to stop Heugung. Jin Taekyung was badly injured and would not wake for at least several days. The White Tiger, a spiritual creature capable of holding its own against a Peak master, had been left on the brink of death by a surprise attack.

And Yohi herself had collapsed under the pill's effects without so much as swinging her sword.

So how can the seal be gone?

She was not even tied up with rope or chains. Her martial arts might not be especially formidable, but she had reached the early Peak realm.

For Dark Heaven, this would have been a strangely careless way to hold her.

Could it be…?

Yohi swallowed, keeping the rest of the thought to herself. She rose carefully and took a closer look around.

Her eyes had adjusted to the dark. With internal energy sharpening her vision, she could now see farther into it.

This is…

The moment she understood the shape of the place, her breath caught.

It was enormous—far too large to have been made to imprison one person.

The size alone was not what unsettled her. It seemed to extend for hundreds of zhang[2976] in every direction, but that hardly mattered beside the cold, damp stone surrounding her. It covered the floor, the walls, even the ceiling.

An impregnable fortress with no way in or out.

What in the world is this place?

Yohi was staring at the stone and the thick vines spread across it when a wind blew from somewhere.

Swoooosh.

[2976] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length equal to ten chi, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The vines swayed. Yohi stood with her mouth open, letting the cool air wash over her. Something fell from above, and she reached out.

Rustle. Tap.

She caught it between her fingers.

It was a leaf from one of the vines, fallen past her silky hair. Unlike the leaves she had seen in the Poisonblood Grounds, it was green and full of life.

Then a realization struck her.

Wait. Wind?

Wind could not blow through a sealed space. There had to be an opening—and one large enough to let in a gust that could shake those thick vines.

Yet search as she might, Yohi could find no gap.

That can't be right.

She felt along the stone surrounding her, then struck it with internal energy. She even tried imitating the Wall Lizard Technique, which she had never learned, and climbed the vines in case there was an opening overhead.

Every attempt came to nothing.

She had stopped despairing over being captured by Dark Heaven. Now she was simply at a loss in a place she could not understand.

There has to be an exit, at least.

More than two shichen[2977] had passed since she woke, and she had spent that time searching. She had found nothing resembling an exit, let alone a gap.

Then who had put her here? And how?

Yohi sank to the ground and leaned against the stone wall. Warmth and softness met her back, making her feel a little better.

"Hm?"

Something was wrong.

She blinked, then slowly tipped her head back without moving away.

A pair of blue-white eyes looked down at her through the dimness.

"Ah."

—Grrr.

A suffocating silence fell.

Yohi rose slowly, looking from the cliff-like wall behind her to the massive White Tiger protruding from it. Only its upper body showed, as though the rest had been cut away.

What is this?

She tried to take stock of the situation.

First, she was in an enormous place she knew nothing about.

[2977] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

Second, stone blocked even the sky, as though she were trapped inside a cliff. There was no visible exit.

Third, a White Tiger with half its body missing had appeared from the wall. No—it had suddenly sprung out of it.

Fourth, there were only two possible explanations.

A dream. Or the afterlife.

Yohi did not hesitate. She slammed her head against the rock wall.

Thud.

Her skull rang, but she did not wake up. The afterlife it was.

Besides, that White Tiger floating there with only its upper body showing looked familiar.

That's the one.

Snow-white fur that could almost be called silver. Blue-white eyes.

It was the White Tiger that Young Palace Lord Yayul Mok treasured.

Muyaho should have been dead. Yet here it was without a scratch, calmly tilting its head at her. Yohi was certain now: she was in the afterlife.

No wonder there's no exit.

How was she supposed to know? She had never been here before.

It felt as though a hopelessly tangled thread had finally come loose. With that moment of enlightenment, Yohi's shoulders began to shake.

"Sniff… You fucking bastard, Heugung…"

The crisis facing Nanman? Her dignity as Great Chieftain of the Yao people?

What did any of that matter? She was dead.

The only one watching her was a half-severed tiger ghost. Then she thought of her mother, who had died twenty years ago, and tears poured down her face.

"Waaah! Waaaaah!"

At her cries, which sounded almost like a wild beast's roar, Muyaho approached with a look that seemed to ask if she was one of its own kind. It licked away her tears.

—Grrr.

A rough tongue swept across her whole face.

Her senses did seem awfully vivid for a ghost. Then again, anyone who claimed the dead could not feel anything had probably never been to the afterlife either.

Yohi buried her face in Muyaho's soft fur and wept.

At least, that was what she did until her hand grasped something soft and swishing.

Grab.

—Hiss!

At first, she was too busy crying to notice. Then she wondered what she had caught.

At Muyaho's sharp cry, she raised her head and saw the long, snow-white tail in her hand.

What? It's a tail. I thought it was something else.

Yohi buried her face in the fur again. A moment later, she lifted her head.

One fact had hit her like a blow to the back of the head.

Wait. Why does it have a tail?

Ordinarily, that would not have been strange. Tigers had tails. Even the rats infesting the Western Yao Estate's storerooms had tails.

But moments ago, this White Tiger ghost had been floating there with only its upper body visible. Now it was whole.

Could it be?

Yohi sprang up and reached for the wall where Muyaho had first appeared.

Tap.

It was cold and hard, just as before. She could not guess its thickness, and she saw no gap.

Still, she was not ready to give up.

There's something I don't understand. There has to be.

With her composure returning, reason told her this was neither a dream nor the afterlife. It was something strange—something the human mind could not easily make sense of.

As though it had read her thoughts, Muyaho stopped circling her and moved.

—Grrrr.

The massive White Tiger bent its hind legs to one side. Yohi caught a hint of meaning in its clear blue-white eyes.

"You want me to ride you? On your back?"

—Grrr.

"Hah."

She had heard it was intelligent. She had not realized just how intelligent.

Yohi studied Muyaho with fresh amazement, then carefully climbed onto its back. When she gripped its white fur, it stretched a huge forepaw toward the wall.

Clomp.

It was so enormous that a single step brought the rock wall right in front of them. Yohi squeezed her eyes shut.

Please.

The plea had barely formed when—

Swoooosh!

A strange sensation swept through her, as though she were being pulled somewhere. Yohi slowly opened her eyes.

“Ah.”

It was bright. Warm.

Light instead of darkness. Trees overflowing with life instead of cold rock walls. A place filled with every kind of flower instead of vines.

An entirely new world lay before her. For a moment, its peace and beauty made her forget everything else.

“W-What is this place…?”

Her question trailed off. This time, Muyaho gave no answer.

The white tiger shot down a path lined with plants and flowers without a moment’s hesitation.

Tap-tap. Swoooosh!

A refreshing wind scattered around them, wrapping around their entire bodies. At the same time, beyond the scenery rushing past them, countless animals of every shape and color watched them with curious eyes.

Mountain birds nested in impossibly tall trees. A roe deer and a wild boar basked together amid the thick grass. There was even a bear letting the mismatched pair lean against its body.

What in the world did I just see?

The thought vanished almost as soon as it came.

Why did none of the animals seem to care about the food chain? She did not know. It did not matter.

Here, simply by being in this place, everything felt natural.

This is… This is impossible.

The words *dark arts* flashed through her mind.

Then the path that had seemed to go on forever ended at a small pond.

Someone was there.

“Jin Taekyung!”

It was him.

His well-balanced, muscular body and red armor covering his upper body stood out clearly even from a distance. He was collapsed, half-submerged in the clear water.

Only a little over ten zhang remained between them. But contrary to Yohi’s desperate urgency, the White Tiger’s paws, which had moved forward without pause until now, were fixed in place as though nailed to the ground.

—Grrrr.

Its low growl sounded as though it were calling to someone.

Yohi sensed something and turned to follow its blue-white gaze.

She saw it.

No—she felt it before she saw it.

Swoooosh.

A cool wind carrying an unfamiliar energy stirred the leaves of a tree larger than any she had ever seen. Green leaves rained down.

And then—

Rustle.

Beneath the vast shade of the great tree, a Black Tiger as dark as the shadows rose to its feet.

Chapter 690

The Nanman people revered martial prowess.

Like the Han Chinese of the Central Plains, they farmed, raised livestock, and mined gold and silver from the rivers and mountains. But in the end, what mattered most to them was strength.

What good was wealth? A plentiful harvest and a pen full of livestock still had to be defended.

Warriors. And ferocious beasts capable of fighting alongside them.

They were swords to drive into an enemy's chest and shields to protect this land.

After a long history of struggle, the Nanman people knew this well. Even after the Five Poisons Sect was destroyed and the Nanman Beast Palace was established, they devoted considerable effort to raising warriors and beasts alike.

Great tribes and small tribes were no different. Without strength, they would be pushed aside and brought to ruin.

Yohi, Great Chieftain of the Yao people and one of the leaders of Nanman's four great tribes, thought much the same way. If anything, her ambition made her more zealous than the other tribal chieftains.

She invested the gold and silver she had received for turning a blind eye to Baeksang's actions in her tribe's fighting strength. She recruited talented young people and trained them as warriors. She studied the strengths and weaknesses of different beasts and even improved them through selective breeding.

But…

Rustle.

The moment *that thing* rose from the shade, Yohi felt her heart sink. She had faced countless ferocious beasts, yet this one struck her like a bolt of lightning through the crown of her head.

"…!"

In sheer size and strength, no beast could match an elephant. As large as a small hill, it had a long, thick trunk strong enough to snap trees and sharp tusks that could pierce armor.

But *that thing*—that Black Tiger—was different.

Yohi felt the tremendous, overwhelming aura emanating from the black tiger, unlike anything she had seen before.

Th-This is…

It was not simply a matter of size or appearance. If an elephant was a small hill, the Black Tiger was Taishan.

It had neither an elephant's long, thick trunk nor its sharp tusks. Yet simply standing there, it seemed powerful enough to cut through and crush anything.

Beast was not the word for it. A spiritual creature? No, that would not do either.

The Black Tiger reflected in her eyes now radiated an aura far deeper and more overwhelming than that of any spiritual creature.

What in the world is that…?

As Yohi swallowed a low groan, a cool wind flowed outward from the Black Tiger and swept over the clearing.

Swoooosh.

Grass and flowers bent in every direction, and the clear water in the small pond rippled. As the wind passed over her, a memory flashed through Yohi's mind.

I've felt this wind before. Twice.

She had thought nothing of it at the time. Now she remembered: a wind like this had blown just before she lost consciousness from the pill Heugung gave her, and again when she first woke in that vast, unfamiliar space.

Then was it the Black Tiger that saved us from Heugung…?

Yohi's eyelids trembled. But before she could speak, the Black Tiger turned away. It had been watching the unfamiliar intruder in silence, its blue-white eyes much like Muyaho's. Now it disappeared behind the enormous tree.

Swoooosh.

The wind slowly died down.

Yohi approached the tree cautiously, but the Black Tiger was nowhere to be seen beneath its broad shade.

It had vanished like a ghost, without a trace or the faintest sign of its presence.

"…!"

How?

She felt bewitched. If Muyaho had not called out just then, she might have stood there in a daze for a long time.

—Grrr.

Tap.

A damp nose touched her elbow. Yohi jerked her head up as though waking from sleep and remembered someone she had forgotten for a moment.

Jin Taekyung.

Her mind was still tangled with unanswered questions, but something more important needed her attention. She hurried to the pond and checked his condition.

A faint breath escaped his nose and mouth. Fortunately, he had only fallen into a deep sleep from accumulated fatigue. His condition was not bad.

In fact, he seemed much better than when she had last seen him.

Is it my imagination?

Yohi tilted her head and took hold of both his arms. No matter how clear the water was, his wounds would struggle to heal if it seeped into them. She meant to pull him out of the pond, where he lay half-submerged.

But just as she started to lift him—

Tap.

A snow-white forepaw came down over the back of her hand. Yohi thought she understood the gesture.

“You want me to leave him there?”

—Grrr.

“I’m sorry, but I can’t do th—”

—Grrrr!

Slash. Splash!

It happened in an instant. A sudden pain sent Yohi tumbling into the pond. She stared at the White Tiger in shock.

The back of her hand stung. Blood from the skin grazed by its sharp claws spread red across the water’s surface.

Why?

Her confusion lasted only a moment. Soon she understood why the remarkably intelligent White Tiger had done it.

Sss.

“The wound… Is it healing?”

It was. Yohi stared wide-eyed at the back of her hand beneath the clear water.

The cut flesh slowly knitted together, and the bleeding stopped. Slowly, but unmistakably. The sight was so astonishing that she forgot the pain of the wound closing.

She lifted her hand for a closer look. The flesh stopped healing, and a faint trickle of blood appeared again.

The pond. It stopped because I took my hand out.

She dipped her hand back into the water. At once, the wound began to close.

“…A pond that heals wounds.”

It sounded even more far-fetched than the legendary gongcheong seokyu, an elixir said to grant a jiazi’s[2978] worth of internal energy with a single drop. Yet Yohi was no longer surprised. She had seen it with her own eyes and felt it for herself.

This strange space could not be explained by the four words *Mystic Gate Formation*. Then there was the unknown Black Tiger—and the wound on her hand, already healed without a trace.

At last, she thought she understood how Muyaho had survived a sword wound to the nape of its neck.

[2978] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

"So that's why you stopped me. He'll recover faster if he stays in the pond."

—Grrr.

Muyaho gave a faint growl and slowly licked the back of her hand.

"Then did that Black Tiger that vanished a moment ago save us? Was it the one that treated you and Jin Taekyung too?"

Muyaho nodded emphatically.

"Why? Do you know what the Black Tiger is? Who its master is? Do you know where we are?"

Muyaho hesitated, then shook its head.

Only seven days and nights ago, Muyaho had followed the Beast Miao King and Jin Taekyung to Ailao Mountain and already encountered the Black Tiger once. Yet even to an innate spiritual creature like Muyaho, the Black Tiger's existence was an incomprehensible mystery.

"Haah. You don't know either."

—Whiiine.

"It's all right."

Yohi stroked the dejected Muyaho's neck, though her own thoughts remained tangled. She knew too little to make sense of anything.

Where were they? How much time had passed? And when would Jin Taekyung regain consciousness?

At least one thing was certain: the unknown Black Tiger had shown them goodwill.

It has nothing to do with Dark Heaven, at least. If it did, we'd all be dead.

Her gaze settled on Jin Taekyung. He lay half-submerged, motionless as a corpse. Whether he knew anything of what was happening around him, he slept on with a perfectly peaceful expression.

If I had been the one who collapsed instead of him… If Jin Taekyung had been awake, every problem would have been solved.

Perhaps it was only a foolish thought born of desperation. Yet somewhere along the way, Yohi had come to trust him from the bottom of her heart.

He had the martial prowess to defeat two Supreme Peak masters alone, and he had compassion and a sense of what was right. She merely wore the hide of a Great Chieftain while being little better than a traitor. He had done more than anyone to save Nanman from danger.

If she could not trust him, whom could she trust?

If Baeksang and Dark Heaven have begun moving in earnest, Palace Lord Yayul won't be able to oppose them with his strength alone. There's not enough time.

Most of what Yohi feared was already coming to pass.

While she had no way to mark the passing time, the Beast Miao King had been branded a traitor. He had escaped the Nanman Beast Palace, now enemy territory, and vanished. All of Nanman was boiling like an iron cauldron over hot coals.

No—perhaps it was lava that would melt even the cauldron.

Warriors from every tribe that had answered the general mobilization order marched toward the Outer Palace. With their entire leadership imprisoned, the Miao people held their breath amid the chaos. And in a secret refuge known to no one, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled brightly on the verge of completing her grand plan.

Yohi knew none of this. She could not have known. Trapped in this strange, unknown space, all she could do was pray.

If Heaven exists, please…

Please wake him as soon as possible. Even if I have to die, please wake at least one person from this deep sleep.

But with her eyes squeezed shut around that desperate wish, Yohi missed the tiny, unmistakable change right in front of her.

Tap.

A finger moved ever so slightly. Concentric ripples spread across the water, traveling farther and farther outward.

I dreamed.

I knew it was a dream for a simple reason. The moment I opened my eyes, I saw a face that was endlessly familiar. I heard a voice, too, one that time had slowly begun to erase from my memory.

“Oh, what got you up at this hour? Why aren’t you sleeping more?”

My throat tightened. My chest ached.

Holding back the tears that surged into my eyes, I greeted him.

It’s been a long time, Dad.

But my lips moved of their own accord, and the voice that came out was thick with sleep.

Dunno. I just woke up.

Only then did I realize I had no part to play in this dream. I could only watch an old memory unfold.

My father, who had no way of knowing that, grinned.

“You little punk, I’m touched. How did this sleepyhead know Dad was leaving for work and wake up all on his own? Huh?”

His rough fingers poked my cheek. The younger me grumbled at the teasing.

“Ah, stop it. I’m going back to sleep.”

"You punk. Why go back to sleep? The sun's already high in the sky."

"What time is it?"

"Six o'clock. Perfect time to start the day, isn't it?"

"Yeah. I really don't think so."

The younger me buried his face in the pillow. My father laughed and got to his feet.

"Sleep, son. Dad's off to work."

"Huh? Already? It's only six."

"I have to head out of town early. Might be home late today."

I repeated the words desperately in my head.

I can't let him go. Dad, please don't go. Please.

But the younger me was different. He was young and thoughtless. He had no idea that this moment would become his last memory with his father.

"Yeees. Have a good day."

The words came out thick with sleep. My father grinned at me and ruffled my hair affectionately.

"Okay. See you later."

That was all. My father would turn away. The door would close. A few hours later, my homeroom teacher would call me in.

That was how I remembered it.

But…

"By the way, son."

"…!"

At the sudden sound of his voice, I shot upright.

This time it was my own will—not the younger me's, but mine, now in my late twenties.

My father tapped the watch on his wrist and spoke with a laugh in his voice.

"Shouldn't you be getting up soon?"

At that moment—

Crack.

Everything around me shattered and fell away. The familiar ceiling. The room. My father's face.

Something cold washed over my whole body.

Splash!

Through the spray of water scattering in every direction, I saw a woman's wide-open eyes.

A trembling voice soon pierced my ears.

"…How?"

Who knows.
I muttered inwardly, like the young boy in the dream that still felt so vivid.
Dunno. I just woke up.

Chapter 691

Sometimes a dream is so wonderful, so hard to leave behind, that you don't want to wake up. Even after you do, you keep your eyes closed a while longer, going over everything that happened in it.

But as always, things didn't go the way I wanted.

"Jin Taekyung!"

—Grrr!

Two figures, one large and one small, rushed at me with cries that sounded almost like screams. It wasn't hard to guess what was about to happen.

Or to prevent it.

Thwack. Splash!

I tripped Yohi and shoved away Muyaho's drooling muzzle. Then I closed my eyes again.

"Three seconds. Just leave me alone for three seconds."

I counted to three in my head. Very slowly. I recalled everything I'd seen in the dream, held it in my mind, and opened my eyes again.

Above me was an unfamiliar sky. I couldn't even tell whether it was day or night.

An unfamiliar sky, huh?

That was a new one. How could the sky I saw whenever I looked up feel unfamiliar? But there it was, right in front of my eyes.

I pushed myself upright, my body throbbing.

"First, a question. You're not about to tell me Dark Heaven took over Nanman while I was unconscious, are you?"

Soaked from her fall into the pond, Yohi stared at me in disbelief.

"That's what you say after tripping me the moment you wake up?"

"You rushed at me the moment I opened my eyes. And look at the sky. I'd believe you if you told me this was hell."

"What would you do if it was?"

"Who knows?"

I looked around.

A pond full of clear water. Lush trees and plants. Mountain birds chirped in the thickets surrounding us, where wild animals watched with curious eyes.

The scenery's a little too nice for hell.

I shrugged.

"I'd already be dead. Might as well go back to sleep."

"…Sleep? Are you out of your mind?"

"No. In fact, everything is still spinning in front of my eyes."

It was true. Just sitting up made my whole body ache and left me dizzy.

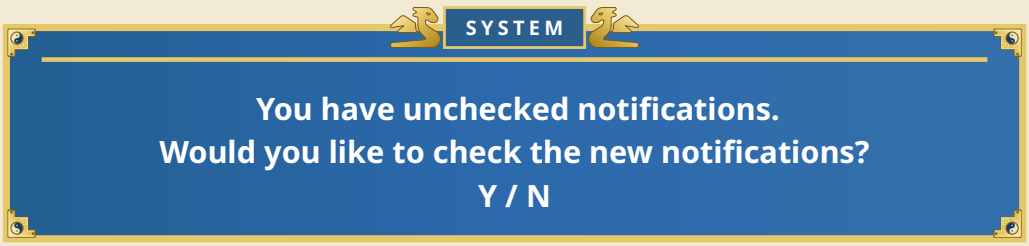
Still…

“I do seem to be alive. Definitely.”

Yes. I’d survived again.

The pain washing over me and the System notifications ringing in my ears were proof enough.

Ding.



I was about to open the System window when I remembered something and turned my head.

Blue-white eyes shone as they watched me warily. Behind them, a tail spun like a propeller. I let out a quiet laugh.

“Yeah. I’m alive thanks to you.”

—Kraaang!

With a whoosh!

Muyaho hurled his enormous body at me as though he’d been waiting for those words.

My not-quite-healed body screamed beneath his weight, but that was all right. It was a good kind of pain. It reminded me I was alive.

Crunch.

“…Ah.”

It was starting to feel less good.

Fortunately, Muyaho’s assassination attempt—which had made me suspect he might actually be Dark Heaven—ended in failure. After confirming that my ribs were still in place, I asked what I was most curious about.

“Where’s Heugung? Why don’t I see him?”

Yohi’s face stiffened the instant I said his name.

“Don’t even mention that bastard.”

“Wait. Don’t tell me…”

“Yes. It’s what you’re thinking.”

“Heugung proposed to you?”

"…!"

"What a lunatic. No matter how much he likes you, how could he propose *then*?"

Yohi stared at me as though I were the lunatic.

"He wasn't the Heugung we knew. He fooled all of us."

"I'll say. Once he used the Bone-Shrinking Technique, he turned out to be a pretty good-looking guy."

"…The Bone-Shrinking Technique? You knew?"

"Of course. He sent me a secret letter, and we met."

"Then you knew Dark Heaven had planted him as a spy?"

"Of course I knew th—what?"

What had I just heard?

I thought for a moment before asking, "Is that true?"

"Do I look like I'm lying?"

Fuck. It's true.

Only then did I remember the Quest to follow the tracking scent. Now I understood why the System had singled out Yohi by name.

"Okay. I take back what I said about Heugung being good-looking. My apologies."

I shouldn't have said it at all. To hell with his looks—the mood had gone cold long ago. Yohi answered with a sigh.

"It doesn't matter. I survived thanks to you."

"Oh, and I'm sorry about the proposal thing."

"That's fine. He did propose."

"What?"

"He did. Though it was less a proposal than a threat from someone who had my life in his hands."

"Did you… accept?"

"I've been meaning to ask. Are you actually fucking insane?"

"Uh, sorry. My head's a mess. I keep saying stupid things."

The back of my head still tingled. It was true that I had once suspected Heugung, but after running into the two old monsters in the Poisonblood Grounds, I had erased even that slight suspicion.

But Heugung, that bastard, was Dark Heaven's lackey?

He'd been the knife in the sleeve. One last move the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had kept in reserve.

And the question that came to me again at this point was how Yohi and Muyaho had managed to avoid that move. From what Yohi had said earlier, they must have been in serious trouble.

"What happened to Heugung?"

"He's dead."

After a moment, she added, "Probably."

"Probably?"

"We don't know exactly what happened. That White Tiger was at death's door, and I passed out because of the pill he gave me. When I woke up, I was here."

The rest of her account was brief. They didn't know where they were or how much time had passed outside. Muyaho had been moments from death, and I'd been severely injured. Both of us had survived thanks to this mysterious pond.

"I know. It must sound impossible. But really…"

"I get it."

"What?"

"I get it. All of it."

What was so hard to believe about a pond that healed wounds?

Only people of this world would be unable to understand such a phenomenon.

I had come from the modern world, where potions, Magic, monsters, and Gates existed. Even if a few Orcs crawled out from those bushes right now, I was confident I wouldn't bat an eye.

"…"

On second thought, I might raise an eyebrow. Orcs appearing in Murim wouldn't exactly be normal.

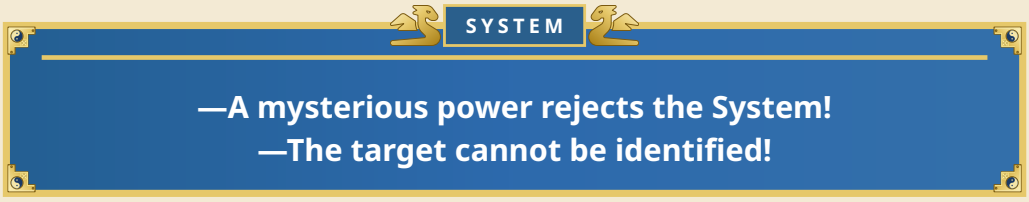
Unless an actual Gate opened here, like back home.

I reached out and skimmed the still surface of the pond.

Its effects were much like a potion's. My father making an entrance like General Kim Jwa-jin[2979] couldn't have been the only reason I'd shaken off the exhaustion in my mind and body so quickly.

Item Appraisal.

Beep.



There it was.

I'd expected as much. Everything about this place was a mystery, from one thing to the next.

And Yohi was about to give me one more.

[2979] Kim Jwa-jin (1889–1930) was a Korean independence activist and military commander.

“I saw a Black Tiger. A black tiger that felt stronger and more extraordinary than any beast I’ve ever encountered.”

“…!”

Splash.

My trembling fingertips disturbed the surface of the water, which had been slowly settling. I swallowed a groan as I watched the ripples spread into the distance.

Ailao Mountain’s Wraith…

The enormous Black Tiger flashed through my mind. I’d seen it only once, but I could never forget it.

It had appeared like a ghost, true to its name, then vanished the same way. I could still see it clearly.

And that was the first and last time.

That night, the Beast Miao King and I had discovered the Poisonblood Grounds while pursuing it, but the tiger itself had been nowhere to be found. The Nanman Beast Palace investigators sent out after the fight with the Thousand-Year Spider had found no trace of it either. Then one crisis after another had pushed it to the back of my mind.

Now it had appeared here.

And from the looks of it, it saved us.

I didn’t know what it was or why it had done that. Frowning, I gave the System a command in my head.

Check notifications.

Ding.

With a clear bell only I could hear, holographic windows that had been held back burst into the air.

SYSTEM

—Level Up!
—Some injuries have recovered due to the effects of Level Up!
—Some Status effects have been removed due to the effects of Level Up!
—You have achieved the exceptional achievement The Legend of One Against Two!
—The achievement Reward has been granted!
—You acquired bonus points!
—You acquired a large amount of EXP and Fame!
—A sudden Quest, The Knife in the Sleeve, has been created!
—The sudden Quest has been forcibly canceled!
—You discovered ???!
—A sudden Quest, ???, is pending. It will proceed once all activation conditions have been met!

I was only seeing them now. The System had kept doing its job while I was unconscious.

The problem was that even a System as all-knowing as a god couldn't give me a straight answer.

Those question marks are supposed to bother the hell out of me, right?

As I stared intently at the last two notifications—the ones that bothered me most—Muyaho, who had been circling me for a while, thrust his enormous head at me.

—Nnngh. Ngh.

"Need to poop? Go over there. Hyung's[2980] busy."

—Whiiine.

"I said I'm bu—"

I stopped and looked up.

Something was looking down at this place from atop the cliffs encircling the pond, without giving off the slightest hint of its presence.

That's...

Before I could finish the thought, an unexpected voice rang out inside my head.

—You're awake, human.

"...!"

—Come up. We need to talk.

[2980] *Hyung* is a Korean term a male speaker uses for an older brother or an older male he is close to. Here it is used playfully as a way of referring to himself.

At that moment, I remembered something from a few months ago: the time when an imugi[2981] that had failed to become a dragon sent a thought into my mind from within a broad, deep river.

I climbed the cliff alone, leaving Yohi and Muyaho behind.

My body was still in poor shape, but I made it to the moss-covered top. There, at last, I faced a massive Black Tiger dark as the shadows.

Ailao Mountain's Wraith. It was the same one.

"What… are you?"

At my first words, the Black Tiger stared at me with eyes of unfathomable depth.

—I don't know.

"What?"

—Even I don't know what I am. Too many years have passed for me to remember everything, and I've been called by many names.

"…Ailao Mountain's Wraith."

—I haven't heard that name in a long time. Was it around two hundred years ago?

It sent the thought calmly and took a step. It clearly had a physical body, yet it moved like a ghost. I heard nothing and sensed no movement at all.

Just as I was seized by the sensation that every hair on my body was standing on end, the thought continued.

—But you know what kind of being I am, human.

"…"

—There's no use denying it. I've already confirmed his existence through you.

The Black Tiger slowly turned and opened its mouth. Between its jaws lay something brilliantly blue and clear.

The Water God Dragon's Origin Essence.

"When the hell did you steal this, you bastard?"

[2981] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore associated with the prospect of becoming a dragon.

Chapter 692

Sometimes instinct beats reason.

Like the moment I saw the Water God Dragon's Origin Essence nestled so prettily in the Black Tiger's mouth.

"You bastard. When did you steal that?"

—…

The words slipped out before I could stop them.

The Black Tiger gave me a cold look, then sent a thought my way.

—"Steal" is a strong word.

It was a little strong.

Even if he really had stolen the Water God Dragon's Origin Essence, he could swallow it whenever he wanted. Under the circumstances, I was the one who had to apologize.

"Fine. I'm sorry."

I held out both hands politely.

"Now spit it out. You can see my palm, right? Spit it out here. Ptooey. Come on."

—It was astonishing.

"Yeah, I'm pretty shocked too. I get it, so first, could you just…"

—I felt the power within it. Then I saw a vast stretch of time.

I stopped. "Time?"

—Yes. It was several hundred years of time and memory, visible only to beings of the same kind. Everything belonging to an imugi[2982] who had failed to become a dragon was contained within it.

"…!"

—At the end of those ancient memories, there was a human. Young, rough, and endlessly reckless.

The Black Tiger's blue-white eyes, so much like Muyaho's, rested on me. Then another thought echoed through my mind in what sounded like a man's calm voice.

—Be grateful to that imugi[2983]. If I had not seen his memories, you would all have met the same end as that unpleasant human.

The world was full of unpleasant humans. Turn the whole place upside down and shake them out, and there'd be enough to fill the Yangtze and then some. But I had a pretty good idea who the Black Tiger meant.

"Don't tell me… Heugung?"

[2982] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

[2983] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

—I do not know his name. Unlike you, though, he had only one forepaw.

Technically, it was a hand. That wasn't important right now.

I looked at the Black Tiger with fresh eyes.

"Should I start by thanking you for saving me?"

—It does not matter. It was my choice.

"Then I'll thank you anyway. I mean it."

The Black Tiger glanced at me, turned, and began to walk. I fell into step behind him.

"I have a few questions."

—How tiresome.

"What? You'll answer them all sincerely even though it's a bother?"

—No.

"Oh. Thanks for agreeing so readily."

—…Human communication is truly strange. Have too many years passed?

I ignored that and asked the most important question first.

"How much time has passed?"

His tail hung stiffly, plainly showing his displeasure. Still, the answer came.

—You have been here for one day, by human reckoning.

"One day?"

Ordinarily, that would be no time at all.

But under the circumstances, it was a different story.

The Great Snow Fiend and the Black Hand Fist Demon had warned of the bloodbath about to sweep Nanman. With even the Beast Miao King's whereabouts unknown, no one was left to stop the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Damn it.

The situation had been unavoidable, but it wouldn't have been strange if thousands—or tens of thousands—had died during the one day I was unconscious.

I clenched my teeth, swallowed a curse, and forced out the words.

"An exit. Tell me how to get out of here."

—You intend to leave?

"Yeah. I'm grateful you saved me, but I can't waste any more time."

—You intend to save your own kind from danger. Recklessly, as you did before.

"You…?"

—Do not worry. I cannot read human memories. I saw you in the imugi's[2984] memories and made a guess. I imagine you fought so fiercely for much the same reason.

"…You were watching?"

[2984] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

—Yes. From beginning to end. As always, I watched everything that happened here.

The Black Tiger turned his head toward me, his thoughts as calm as ever.

—But I saw no reason to involve myself in human affairs. Not until you brought out *that*.

"…!"

My eyes widened. Not because I knew he meant the Water God Dragon's Origin Essence.

I remembered reaching for the Origin Essence in one last desperate attempt to stay alive—only to hesitate when a chill wind blew in from somewhere. At the same time, I sensed something strange and let go of the Origin Essence. Muyaho arrived immediately afterward and saved my life.

"Then that wind…"

My voice trailed off. The Black Tiger's answer sounded in my head.

—You were about to do something foolish. If you defy what is ordained, that is defying Heaven. Had I done nothing, you would have died, unable to overcome the power left behind by the imugi[2985].

I watched him walk along the endless cliff.

"Not once, but twice."

—What do you mean?

"You saved me twice."

The Black Tiger gave a small snort.

—I merely felt sorry for someone who had handed everything they possessed to a foolish human. Without that reason, you deserved to die.

"That's a little unfair. I don't know why you hate humans, but I've never done anything bad enough to deserve that."

—Even after you tried to take innocent lives and set fire to their peaceful home?

"What?"

Instead of answering, the Black Tiger nodded toward the foot of the cliff.

Countless beasts, their bodies blackened in places, drank from an unfamiliar stream. There were thousands of them by my rough estimate. With all the others that might be sheltering somewhere in this seemingly boundless place, I couldn't begin to guess the total.

What the hell…?

I stood on the cliff, staring down at them.

—The inferno you unleashed is still devouring the entire mountain. If the flames had spread unchecked, everything would have burned away long ago.

"…"

[2985] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

—Yes, I led them here. Just as I did seven days and nights ago.

Seven days and nights ago.

That had been the very day the Beast Miao King and I received the emergency report and headed for Ailao Mountain.

I searched my memory, and realization struck.

The beasts.

I remembered clearly. Of the three hundred or so warriors stationed at Ailao Mountain, about two hundred had returned alive.

The beasts hadn't.

I hadn't seen them anywhere—not on Ailao Mountain, not in the Poisonblood Grounds.

"You were the one who did that too. You saved the wild beasts."

—Monsters that should never have been there were set loose. I had not interfered in human affairs for hundreds of years, but that time I could not stand aside.

Ordinarily, I might have let that pass. But I was listening closely to the Black Tiger's thoughts, and I caught the oddity at once.

"Set loose?"

—You did not know?

Faint contempt entered his blue-white eyes.

—Humans did all of it. Your kind has done such things since long ago, and I have remained here and watched.

Damn it.

I'd only been able to guess what had happened at Ailao Mountain. Now the Black Tiger had confirmed it.

Dark Heaven had been behind that, too.

If only we'd found out a little sooner.

With belated regret, I looked at the Black Tiger. I thought I was beginning to understand why he had acted that way that day. I remembered his back as he repeatedly appeared and disappeared, even though he could have escaped at any time.

"You weren't attacking us that day."

—Yes. That was not my mission.

"You were trying to show us where the Thousand-Year Spider was."

—I could not simply watch while a foul monster disturbed this mountain. Humans planted the seed, so humans should reap it. That is the natural order.

He walked on. The path along the cliff grew narrower and steeper, and birds nesting on rugged peaks above the clouds watched us with curious eyes.

How long had we been walking? Clouds and mist surrounded us, and the ground below seemed impossibly far away.

I'm sure this place wasn't this big.

When I first woke, I'd thought it was a forest around a small pond. Now I could see vast mountain ranges, valleys, and green pastures.

What the hell is this place?

I could no longer begin to guess. Staring at the impossible landscape, I finally asked, "Where are we?"

—A land filled with life. A place where all things live in harmony.

What kind of nonsense was that?

For some reason, I remembered the church deacon who used to give me spicy rice cakes when I was little while shouting, "Jesus, heaven! Unbelievers, hell!"

"Even so, this can't be heaven."

—The kingdom of heaven? A fitting description, in its way. But this place lies deep within the land, where no one can enter without my permission. It is very close to where you were.

"Then… are we in the Poisonblood Grounds?"

A few paces ahead, the Black Tiger gave a small nod.

—It is.

"But this place…"

The words stuck in my throat. The Poisonblood Grounds?

I wouldn't have believed we were anywhere on Ailao Mountain. There were no raging flames here, none of the eerie feeling that hung over the mountain.

—Enough. This is a place that you humans can neither invade nor understand.

He was right. Murim had all manner of strange things, Mystic Gate Formations among them, but what lay before me went far beyond anything they could do.

"Ha. The Poisonblood Grounds. This is the Poisonblood Grounds."

Laughing hollowly, I followed him up the peak.

As we neared the summit, his thought reached me again.

—Poisonblood Grounds is its current name. As I did, humans changed many things over the passage of time.

"What was it called before?"

—The Sacred Land.

"What?"

—That was in a past as distant as the imugi's[2986] memories. Beasts, not humans, ruled this land then. The few humans lived in groups within their own territories and worshiped us.

"Huh."

I had no words.

[2986] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like creature associated with becoming a dragon.

This forbidden place, where no one could set foot, had once been called the Sacred Land. And if there had been so few people in Nanman back then… how long ago was that?

Five hundred years? A thousand?

This is driving me crazy.

Even if I'd put every point into Intelligence from the start, I'd have felt like an idiot right now.

I shook my head and opened my mouth toward the Black Tiger, who had stopped walking before I noticed.

"Then you. What exactly are you?"

—Did you not call me an apparition yourself?

"I'm asking what they called you when this place was the Sacred Land."

The Black Tiger was silent for a moment before moving his massive body. Something wistful passed through his blue-white eyes.

—A guardian spirit.

"What?"

—Long ago, that was what people called me. The mountain lord[2987] who guarded Ailao Mountain. A guardian spirit born alongside the sacred stone.

[2987] "Mountain lord" is a traditional epithet for a tiger.

Chapter 693

The Beast King Stone.

The name felt familiar. A memory from not so long ago surfaced with it.

About seven days and nights earlier, on our way to Ailao Mountain, the Beast Miao King had told me a story from the distant past. Why Ailao Mountain had become a forbidden land. How the Five Poisons Sect had given rise to the Nanman Beast Palace as it existed today. The Great War that had stained all of Nanman with blood.

And… a vanished divine artifact.

It's a legend passed down only by word of mouth. The Beast King Stone is our Palace's divine artifact, said to have been carried by the first Palace Lord. Supposedly, it could make every wild beast under Heaven obey.

I remembered the Beast Miao King's offhand remark.

—Look.

At the quiet thought echoing in my head, the apparition—no, the being I should now call a guardian spirit—slowly stepped aside.

Only then could I see it.

Ssshhh.

The Black Tiger's massive body had been blocking my view. Beyond him, at the summit of a peak shrouded in thick mist, stood a colossal boulder.

No way.

I knew at once why the Black Tiger had brought me here. I knew what that boulder was.

Step.

I walked forward as if entranced, passed the Black Tiger, and stopped before the stone. It stood nearly thirty feet[2988] tall.

Ssshhh.

I could feel an unknown energy wrapped around it like an embrace.

Here, at the highest point of this impossible land, the boulder shed a faint, ink-dark glow. It looked mysterious and dangerous—like a divine artifact from some legend buried by the ages.

"…The Beast King Stone."

The three words escaped with the breath I'd been holding. The Black Tiger appeared beside me like a ghost and gave a small nod.

—Yes. Long ago, a human gave it that name.

"The human you mean wouldn't happen to be…"

[2988] The Korean measures the stone at nearly three *jang*. Three *jang* equal thirty *cheok*, or about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

—He was refreshing as the wind, clear as water, and steadfast as a tree. He was also the only human who could enter and leave this place freely without my permission.

"Without your permission? Was that possible?"

This place had remained hidden for hundreds of years, perhaps nearly a thousand. We had entered only because the Black Tiger had opened the way for us.

—It was. I did not know it myself, but the sacred stone that guards this land accepted him before I ever gave my permission.

The sacred stone, I realized, was the Beast King Stone's original name. And I had a fair idea who the human was.

Since people had first settled in Nanman, dozens of tribes had fought one another without end. He was the only leader who had ever united them under a single banner.

And that wasn't all.

The man who had etched the five characters Nanman Beast Palace into this land had also been the first and last owner of the Beast King Stone during its brief appearance.

No. Maybe *owner* wasn't the right word.

What the Black Tiger told me next turned that suspicion into certainty.

—Then, one day, a great war broke out. Mountains and grasslands burned. The rivers filled with more human and animal corpses than anyone could count. As the years passed, the land grew more tainted, and the sacred stone slowly lost its power.

"Lost its power?"

—Commanding a hundred beasts was only one of its powers. We call it the sacred stone because it protected this land's abundance for ages beyond memory.

I looked away from the Black Tiger and back at the boulder. Its faint, ink-dark glow hadn't changed. Cracks ran through it, and pieces had broken away.

"Abundance is about the last thing that comes to mind."

How far was it from looking abundant? About as far as I'd traveled from Henan to Nanman.

Its grimy black color was one thing. The ominous energy seeping from it made even me uneasy.

This really isn't what I expected.

Divine artifacts didn't come with factory specifications, but I'd still had a picture in my head: a small, gleaming white stone. Not something that made Seoraksan's Rocking Stone look modest and practically blasted ominous pressure in every direction.

"…I don't know about abundance, but I think I understand why it was called the Beast King Stone. If you smashed something's head with this, what beast wouldn't obey? You could probably rule humans with it too."

And the first Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace had supposedly owned this thing, if only for a while. How hard had he trained? Had he hung an elephant from a pull-up bar and put up a five-thousand total on the big three?[2989]

While I wondered how a legendary figure had measured his total, the Black Tiger fixed me with a somber gaze.

—Because of your kind.

"What?"

—Once, this land was filled with peace and abundance. All things followed the natural order. The sacred stone did not look as it does now.

I realized what he was getting at.

"…It started losing power when humans settled here."

—More precisely, when they began killing one another.

I was beginning to understand. The stone the people of Nanman called the Beast King Stone was practically one with this land. The more death and destruction spread across it, the more power the stone lost.

"So that's why you helped the first Palace Lord? Three hundred years ago, as the Five Poisons Sect stained Nanman with blood, the sacred stone's power would have weakened too?"

—I… No, we…

Something crossed the Black Tiger's eyes. Longing, perhaps. Or regret.

—We did not help him.

"…!"

I stopped short. His calm thought continued.

—My mission was to guard the sacred stone. Its duty was simply to exist alongside this land. All we could do was watch.

"You just… watched?"

—Yes. Like a certain being you know.

I thought of the Water God Dragon I'd met several months ago. The imugi had spent hundreds of years guarding its river and pursuing enlightenment. For all its strange, tremendous power, it had kept to its territory rather than actively intervening in human affairs.

But if that was true…

"Then what was the legend of the Beast King Stone? The story passed down to the people here…"

[2989] The "big three" are the squat, bench press, and deadlift. In Korean gym talk, their combined lifting total is given in kilograms; five thousand kilograms is about 11,000 lb.

—A legend. Yes, it was exactly that—a legend. Something that clearly existed, but could only be fabricated as fiction.

Bitterness flickered through his blue-white eyes.

—He was the only human who could understand our mission, and he wanted peace more than anyone. So, to end this war, he created the Beast King Stone himself.

"…!"

—I watched from where no one could see. I watched him name a powerless stone the Beast King Stone, become a chosen hero, unite the tribes, and fight other humans. I watched until the day he fell.

My breath caught in my throat. It was as though a book densely filled with the legend of a distant past had opened before my eyes.

—That was how he died. The thing humans had revered as the Beast King Stone vanished as though it had never existed. The war continued for another hundred years. And I…

Grrrr.

His growl trembled. He stared at the sacred stone as if he were searching the distance for something he could never reach. Then his blue-white eyes turned to me.

—For two hundred years, I regretted it.

A brief silence followed.

Wind blew from somewhere. I stood facing the Black Tiger and asked, "Why?"

I didn't wait for an answer. I hadn't expected one.

"Because the land grew barren as the war continued, causing the sacred stone to lose its power? Because you thought that even the tiny bit of power it had left would soon disappear when what is about to happen arrives? Is that why you regretted it? Because you should have helped him back then—a pointless regret?"

His reply weighed heavily in my head.

—Are you condemning me?

"No. Honestly, I don't care much about that. I'm grateful you helped us, whether you believe it or not."

I didn't care about the sacred stone or the guardian spirit. I didn't think I had any business caring about either.

It had already happened hundreds of years ago, and whatever their mission might have been, the fact remained that they had saved my life and the lives of my companions.

The thought had just come to me.

"For a guardian spirit, you're pretty petty and cowardly. This much should be okay, right?"

—…!

“Not okay? If I offended you, I’ll take it back.”

The Black Tiger stared at me without a word. His body looked endlessly ominous, but his blue-white eyes were large and clear.

And then.

—For two hundred years, I regretted it every day, every moment. I should have saved that human, even if it meant defying the natural order.

“…!”

—Reckless, young human. You were not wrong. I let a single mission bind me for far too long, and it led me to a mistaken judgment. Will you give me a chance?

“A chance…?”

—I want to restore whatever power I can to the sacred stone. And this time, I want to put right the choice I made in the past.

Ssssh.

The enormous tiger slowly opened his jaws. A crystal of clear blue energy came into view.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

—Conditions met! New information has been updated!
—Apparition of Ailao Mountain has changed to guardian spirit!
—Hidden text has been revealed!
—You have discovered the Hidden Sacred Land!
—You have met the activation conditions for a hidden Quest!
—A hidden Quest has been created!
—The hidden Quest Last Chance has been created!

Bells and System notifications rang out without warning. One final holographic window appeared before my eyes.

SYSTEM

Would you like to enhance the Ancient Sacred Stone with the Water God Dragon’s Origin Essence?
Y / N

A tooth for a tooth. An eye for an eye.

And…

Spiritual energy for spiritual energy, huh?

Muttering inwardly, I suddenly looked up at the sky.

It was blue. Just like the eyes of the Black Tiger watching me.

No—the guardian spirit.

“I…”

Some had gone. Others had stayed behind.

Yohi and Muyaho.

They were waiting by the pond for the one person who had yet to return when something else arrived first.

Rrrrrumble!

The earth shook. Water surged across the pond in waves.

Hundreds, perhaps thousands, of birds took flight at once. Even more beasts rose from the grass.

Yohi reflexively jerked her head up. A faint gasp of shock escaped her lips.

“Th-that’s…”

Kwaaaang!

A pillar of light shot up as if to pierce the sky, enveloping the mysterious space.

Chapter 694

The moon was hidden on a night so dark that only faint flames marked the mountain valley.

One torch, then two, then three. Soon there were hundreds, and the ground began to shake.

Rrrrrumble!

Tremors ran through the earth. Beneath the torches swaying in the wind, shadows large and small pressed forward, their rough breathing unbroken.

Grrrr.

Huff. Huff.

An army.

Humans and beasts, moving as one.

Armed with swords, spears, and bows, the Nanman warriors searched the darkness from their saddles. Beside them, beasts with sharp teeth and claws kept running.

There were three thousand of them. They had left the Outer Palace around noon at one man's command, their destination set from the start.

Ailao Mountain.

The name came to the Captain of the Guards as he rode at the front. At that moment, someone behind him shouted.

"I see it!"

So did everyone else.

Far ahead, an enormous inferno blazed with a force that made their hundreds of torches seem like nothing.

Crack! Whoosh!

Ancient trees toppled one after another. The flames swallowed everything they touched and grew larger still.

The warriors groaned at the sight of a fire unlike any in the past hundred years—and perhaps any in the next hundred.

"H-how can this be?"

"So it really was true…"

Hearing about it was one thing. Seeing it was another.

Shock and fear passed through the warriors' eyes as they stared at Ailao Mountain in flames.

Jin Taekyung.

The rumors about him were all true.

He shook off all those pursuit parties and made it here. What kind of monster is he?

Most of the warriors had never faced Jin Taekyung. More precisely, they had never seen what he was capable of.

Until now, he had been merely an outsider from the Central Plains: a young man with features that looked a little strange to the people of Nanman.

Now they had to fight him.

Their orders were to surround Ailao Mountain so tightly that nothing could slip through, then kill Jin Taekyung whenever he emerged.

But…

Can we stop that monster?

The same question troubled them all.

They had grown up hearing stories of Ailao Mountain, the forbidden land whose history stretched back to the founding of the Nanman Beast Palace. One name always came up in those stories.

The Fire Gate Clan.

An unknown clan said to exist somewhere in the distant Central Plains.

Long ago, its Sect Leader had come to Nanman and ended the Great War against the Five Poisons Sect—a war that had continued for more than a century after the Nanman Beast Palace was founded.

The Five Poisons Sect's deadly poison, which had taken countless lives, and the venomous beasts it commanded had melted like candle wax before the flames he summoned.

It was even said that the Sect Leader of the Five Poisons Sect at the time—who had reduced one hundred of the Nanman Beast Palace's finest warriors to a mere handful of poisonous water—could not withstand his power and fell to his knees.

No. The story said he burned alive.

That old legend, so entertaining when they were children, had stepped out of the past and into the present.

Right before their eyes.

Gulp.

Someone swallowed, the sound strangely loud. Hands tightened around reins that had been held loosely moments before. Anxious glances spread through the ranks.

Then the Captain of the Guards spoke.

"What are you so afraid of?"

"…!"

His voice, carrying internal energy, reached every warrior. He went on, firm and clear.

"He is one man. We are three thousand."

Shoulders that had hunched without their owners noticing began to straighten. One by one, the warriors steadied their gazes.

That's right. No matter how strong he is, he's made of flesh and blood.

Even if every rumor is true, he can't stand against all of us.

Three thousand.

For the killing of one man, it was an absurd number.

The Fire Gate Clan's Sect Leader had supposedly destroyed the Five Poisons Sect through sheer martial prowess. The stories they had grown up with still frightened them, but a legend was a legend.

No—even if he came back to life, it was impossible for him to face three thousand Nanman warriors and beasts of prey alone.

It had to be impossible.

"Have you forgotten? Jin Taekyung is a traitor who put Nanman in danger. He's a Han Chinese man worse than a beast, one who has forgotten the debt of the Great Faction War."

As the inferno drew closer, the Captain's voice grew stronger.

Shing.

"Warriors of Nanman! My proud brothers!"

He drew his sword. Its edge gleamed as moonlight and wavering torchlight broke across the white blade.

"Hunt him down!"

"Waaaaaah!"

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Hundreds, then thousands of weapons came free. Torches flared, and the army urged its mounts toward Ailao Mountain with a roar.

At that instant—

Whoosh!

The Captain of the Guards saw it. Every human and beast there saw it.

A pillar of light rose through the blood-red flames. Against the fire stood the silhouette of a black hill.

No. It wasn't a hill.

Rrrrrumble!

"What is that…?"

The world shook as the dark shape drew nearer. The Captain stared, eyes wide.

He did not notice that he could no longer feel the wind.

He did not know that the three thousand beasts charging relentlessly toward Ailao Mountain had stopped in place as though by prior agreement.

Grrrr.

The tiger that had spent its life at his side gave a low growl and bowed its head.

It was not alone.

Leopards, bears, wolves—every beast, large and small, did the same.

Rustle.

They curled their tails and lowered their massive bodies to the ground.

It was an instinct etched into them at birth: reverence for a king returned after long ages, and a command they could not resist.

—Kraaaaaar!

Along with a roar that devoured the world, blue-white eyes shone in the darkness.

Step. Step.

Quiet footsteps echoed down the silent corridor.

The guards' sharp gazes swept over the maids and servants. Every guard had reached the Peak, and the servants dropped facedown as trembling cries followed.

"W-we pay our respects to the Palace Lord!"

Their fear was meant for one man.

Surrounded by guards, Baeksang walked through the Inner Palace and glanced at the people prostrate before him.

They came from different tribes and were of every age: children still round-cheeked with baby fat, middle-aged men and women, and an old woman whose hair had gone entirely white.

She moved so slowly that she was still struggling in the middle of the corridor. The guards frowned.

Baeksang was the master of the Nanman Beast Palace, the king of this land. Or rather, he had to be. An old woman with little life left could not stand in his way.

Step.

Two guards moved toward her as though they had agreed on it.

"Stop."

They froze at Baeksang's quiet command. He looked at the old woman and greeted her without speaking.

It's been a long time.

He knew her face despite the years. When he and Yayul Cheok had run wild through the Inner Palace as boys, she had been a young woman who sighed whenever she saw them coming.

You've grown old.

Of course she had. His martial prowess at the Supreme Peak had slowed his aging. She had lived under the ordinary passage of time.

"I-I'm sorry, Palace Lord. I'm not as strong as I used to be…"

She bowed and groveled, unable even to raise her head. Baeksang found himself wondering why he had stopped his guards.

Because she was one of the few who remembered him as he had been?

Or because he wanted to delay *that moment*, drawing closer even now?

I don't know. I truly don't.

It left a bitter taste. After coming this far, he still had regrets. And the woman who had once scolded him without a second thought was now too afraid to meet his eyes.

And this is the path I have walked all this time, I suppose.

Empty sentiment. Nothing more.

The days of fighting back-to-back with his only sworn elder brother were long gone. So were the days when they had sat on their enemies' corpses and shared fruit wine, or secretly watched a man and woman meet beneath the dim moonlight.

"…My lord?"

At a guard's cautious call, Baeksang's eyes settled into their usual coldness.

"Clear the way."

"Yes, my lord."

The guards stepped forward at once and shoved the old woman aside.

Baeksang looked down at the others, who pressed themselves even lower to the floor in fear.

"And as of this moment, expel every palace attendant living in the Inner Palace."

"I-I beg your pardon, my lord. Every attendant?"

"Yes. Every one."

The palace attendants lived there and did the work that kept the Inner Palace running. They cooked every meal, cleaned, washed clothes, and handled countless other tasks. Without them, the place would soon cease to function properly.

The guards wanted to ask why. None dared.

Baeksang's word was law.

He was Nanman's only Great Chieftain and the only Palace Lord to have received an oath of absolute loyalty from every tribal chieftain. The five tribes that had left the Outer Palace rather than accept him had been stripped of all authority. Even the Miao leadership was locked in the underground prison.

There was nothing Baeksang could not command.

"…Yes, my lord."

Baeksang watched as the palace attendants, beginning with the old woman, were dragged out in a line, their faces drained of color. Then he muttered inwardly.

Perhaps leaving will be a mercy to you.

Soon everything would begin—and end.

Even Baeksang did not know how much blood would flow before it was over.

No. I can guess. I just don't want to believe it.

Perhaps that was why the past month had shaken him more than any other, though he had lived like a man of iron for more than forty years in pursuit of a single goal.

A whim. Useless in the end.

Yayul Cheok. Jin Taekyung.

Their names crossed his mind as he resumed walking.

Step. Step.

With every step came another thought.

What had become of those two since they disappeared? Where were they now? Did the Southern Heaven Demon Empress know what he had done without anyone else finding out—his final whim?

Too late. No one can undo it now.

Baeksang stopped. Only one door remained before him.

Beyond it lay the highest dais in the Inner Palace. Below it would be the ten thousand warriors gathered in response to the general mobilization order.

Noon. Tomorrow at noon. Gather every warrior in the palace.

There was no doubt. The grand plan was already complete.

Remembering the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's message delivered the previous night, Baeksang suddenly opened his mouth.

"The sun is hot."

"…My lord?"

The door was still shut, yet he could feel a heat that seemed ready to burn him.

What he was about to do was a terrible sin. It could not be forgiven, and it should not be.

But…

There's no other way now, Hwi.

Thinking of the son he missed, Baeksang threw open the door.

The sky opened before him. Below stood the assembled warriors. But his gaze—every one of his senses—was fixed elsewhere.

Beyond the heads of ten thousand warriors, beyond the wall around the Inner Palace and the fortifications of the Outer Palace, lay a green hill.

That's…

It was far away, but Baeksang could see a massive White Tiger standing atop it. Its silver mane shone in the noon sun, and someone sat on its back.

"…You came. After all."

Behind the White Tiger, beasts began to appear.

Thousands of them. Tens of thousands.

Chapter 695

At first, no one paid any attention.

No—no one had time to pay attention to anything else.

Major incidents had followed one after another, and the general mobilization order had swelled their forces by the day. Even ordinary tribespeople in the Outer Palace held their breath, while nearly ten thousand warriors and beasts waited in the Inner Palace for their new Palace Lord.

Yet amid all this, some still stood watch.

“I’m dying out here. It’s hot, everyone’s on edge, and I’m stuck at the North Gate. Should’ve asked for the East or West Gate. They’ve got it easy.”

The young warrior had just returned from patrol. His senior, a graying middle-aged man seated in the shade against the North Gate wall, clicked his tongue.

“Tsk, tsk. Listen to you. Young man with his whole life ahead of him, already looking for a chance to slack off.”

“You’ve been sitting in the shade the whole time I was on patrol.”

“I’m old. If I can’t rest now, when can I?”

“Well, you’ve got me there.”

The Nanman Beast Palace had three gates in total: the East, the West, and the North Gate where they were stationed.

There had never been a South Gate. The sheer cliff behind the Inner Palace was stronger than any gate.

“How was your patrol? What’s the Outer Palace like?”

“Not a rat in the marketplace.”

“…Of course. Everyone’s worried.”

The older warrior sighed.

Nearly ten thousand warriors had gathered in the Inner Palace alone—an army large enough to belong to a small country. Not since the Great Faction War some fifty years ago had so many assembled in one place.

History repeated itself.

Those old enough to remember the past fell silent. Parents pulled their children close and barred their doors. Everywhere, people feared that a vast war was about to begin.

“But… are we really going to war with the Central Plains?”

The older warrior answered his junior’s cautious question in a low voice.

“Who knows? One thing’s certain, though.”

“What’s that?”

“Before we fight in the Central Plains, we’ll shed blood right here in Nanman.”

"…!"

"You know the former Palace Lord is still alive. The five tribal chieftains who support him have left the Outer Palace. The higher-ups will want to settle that before they march on the Central Plains."

The older warrior was hardly the only one to see it coming. Anyone with a little sense and experience could guess what awaited them.

Civil war. Their first in some three hundred years.

To pass through the road leading to the Central Plains, they would have to walk over the corpses and blood of comrades with whom they had shared hardship until only a few days ago.

"…"

A shadow fell across the young warrior's usually carefree face. Among the tribespeople who had left the Outer Palace were close friends he had known since childhood.

The older warrior watched him for a moment, then quietly got to his feet.

"Where are you going?"

"I've slacked off enough. I'll take a look around the wall. My body aches from sitting still."

"Why not keep resting? The other squad's covering the wall anyway—"

"You think those fools are keeping watch? They've probably sneaked down to sit in the shade, same as us. If the higher-ups catch them, I'm the gate captain. I'll be the one getting my ass chewed out."

He had a point. Outsiders almost never came through, so security had never been especially tight. Since nearly ten thousand warriors had taken up position, it had grown laxer still.

Anyone mad enough to attack the Nanman Beast Palace now might as well kill himself.

Besides…

They're all troubled.

Far fewer warriors were eager for a fight than one might expect. Yayul Cheok, now branded a traitor to Nanman, had been a Palace Lord everyone respected. And after three hundred years together beneath the Nanman Beast Palace's banner, the tribes had grown close. They dreaded the civil war and Great War looming before them.

But what could they do? When the people above gave an order, you obeyed.

"Whew."

The older warrior sighed and climbed onto the wall. Just as he had expected, it was quiet up there.

Well, there was at least one man left behind. The problem was that he was asleep and snoring loudly.

…Fine. Rest while you can.

This was the calm before the storm. Today might be the last chance his sorry subordinates had to rest.

Shaking his head, the older warrior stood atop the wall and gazed into the distance.

It was noon.

The sun blazed high overhead. Beyond the North Gate, the broad pasture and the tall hill overlooking the Outer Palace shimmered in the heat haze—

Wait.

What was that? Had he seen it wrong?

His eyes widened. He blinked several times, then rubbed them hard with his sleeve. The sight before him did not change.

“What…?”

The dazed word escaped him before he knew he had spoken.

Far off in the direction he was staring, a massive White Tiger took a step forward.

Step.

Its pure white fur gleamed almost silver. An enormous forepaw brushed the grass, and a wind swept through the forest behind the hill.

Whoosh!

Tangled branches swayed. Countless leaves trembled. Beneath the shade of the dense forest, another forest began to move.

Rumble.

The ground shook. The air shuddered. The wind scattered. Countless eyes with long, slit pupils gleamed in the dark.

“…!”

The older warrior’s mouth slowly fell open.

Beasts. More beasts than he could begin to count.

He was only an ordinary warrior. He had no way to guess how many lurked behind the trees, or where all those predators with their sharp teeth and claws had come from.

But he could guess one thing.

The one leading that chilling host of beasts might be a person, just like him.

Whoosh!

Two silver figures, one large and one small, raced across the pasture on the cool wind.

By then, the number of White Tigers had increased to two. They stopped before the enormous iron gate, along with the man and woman riding on their backs.

Th-that's…

The older warrior's pupils trembled.

Someone else might not have recognized the pair at once. But he had been responsible for the North Gate for ten years, and the moment he saw their faces, it felt as if someone had struck the back of his head with an iron club.

How could he fail to know them?

The woman was one of Nanman's only four Great Chieftains, while the other young man was…

Jin Taekyung.

Merely thinking his name made it hard to breathe.

It was him. The first outsider to come to this land in the centuries since the Five Poisons Sect's destruction. The eye of the vast storm hanging over Nanman.

Jin Taekyung had come to the Nanman Beast Palace of his own accord—with countless beasts and Yohi, the Great Chieftain of the Yao people whom he had supposedly abducted.

Wh-what is going on…?

Before he could finish the thought, the young man who had kept his lips shut until now spoke.

"A word of advice. Take your hand off that."

"…!"

The middle-aged warrior froze just as he instinctively began to sound the alarm. Watching him, Jin Taekyung inwardly let out a sigh of relief.

Thank God. I'm not too late.

One look at the warrior's face had told him Dark Heaven's scheme had not yet begun. If the rift had opened, this place would already be a hellscape where no one could live.

And yet, within this stillness—a stillness so quiet that it felt ominous—he sensed a bomb with its fuse burning down.

"Right, Whitey?"

The enormous body beneath his backside flinched.

The guardian spirit of the sacred stone had regained its former appearance, a White Tiger befitting its title. It sent him a thought.

—…How dare you call this body a name like that?

"You'd have been Blackie before. Not that I'm a racist."

—I have no idea what you're babbling about. Mad human.

A madman, huh? Yeah, I've heard that a fair few times.

Muttering inwardly, Jin Taekyung gave a quiet laugh and lowered the spearhead in his hand.

Was he afraid of what lay ahead? Of course he was.

But he had survived countless brushes with death to reach this place, and he had done everything he could with what he'd been given.

Baeksang. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress. Dark Heaven.

It no longer mattered who stood in his way. He would simply stake his life and fight back.

That's right. Stake my life.

Tens of thousands of lives hung on this battle. Hundreds of thousands. Perhaps more.

Blood might flow like rivers, and corpses might pile up into mountains.

But…

I have to do it.

Someone had once said:

Do everything in your power, then leave the result to Heaven and wait.

But Jin Taekyung thought differently. Only when a person could even change the will of Heaven could it truly be called *Will*.

Isn't that right?

He looked up at the sky. Scorching, dazzling sunlight answered him.

He couldn't die on a day like this.

Then again, he didn't want to die in any weather. He had no intention of it.

Even if the Lord of Heaven was waiting behind the iron gate.

Swish! Slash!

In an instant, a blue-white Force tore through the air like a flash of light and split the enormous iron gate in two.

The guardian spirit, reborn as a dazzling silver White Tiger, let out a roar that shook Heaven and Earth.

—GRAAAAAAAWR!

Its jaws opened wide enough to swallow the world. But teeth harder than steel and a red tongue were not all that lay hidden inside.

Fwoosh!

Brilliant light burst forth, bathing the world in its radiance.

From the sacred stone held in the guardian spirit's mouth, a pillar of light surged over the walls and pierced the sky.

BOOOOM!

It could be seen from a hundred li[2990] away. Perhaps even a thousand.

Everyone saw that strange power, that wondrous sight: the ten thousand warriors gathered in the Inner Palace, and the innumerable beasts filling the hill.

[2990] A Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi). A hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

—Kyaaaaaaau!

—GRAAAWR!

Their roars broke an invisible dam. The beasts that had waited for their master’s command surged like a wave across the vast grassland.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

Thud, thud, thud!

Beneath the blazing sun, the earth shook and the wind scattered.

At the head of them all was one man.

“Let’s go.”

The quiet words slipped from his lips. At the same time, the guardian spirit powerfully kicked off the ground.

Whooosh!

The Great War that would decide Nanman’s fate had begun.

Chapter 696

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

Buildings shook. The earth trembled.

The silence surrounding the Nanman Beast Palace had long since shattered.

In the Outer Palace, tribespeople hiding behind locked doors pulled their young children close. Warriors idling away their shifts atop watchtowers turned their heads—and stared.

“W-what is that…?”

GRAAAAAAAWR!

A tremendous roar that shook Heaven and Earth swallowed the dazed voice that had slipped between someone’s lips.

One warrior finally came to his senses and shouted at the top of his lungs.

“Th-the enemy!”

Most of the others did not move. They could not.

How could they? All they could do was stand with their mouths open and watch an army of beasts race along the dozen or so broad roads through the Outer Palace.

Th-this can’t be.

The sight was as terrifying as it was wondrous.

Thousands—tens of thousands—of beasts ran as one.

No one there had ever seen anything like it. Not even the oldest person in the land. Probably not even his grandfather.

A calamity. Or a miracle.

Faced with something beyond their understanding, the ordinary warriors stood frozen like statues. Even their superior’s shout, the first to break through the shock, reached them like an echo from far away.

“The alarm bell! Ring the alarm bell! Tell the Inner Palace, now!”

“Ah… ah…”

“You idiots!”

The enraged superior shoved aside his dazed subordinate. Then, just as he reached for the rope connected to the alarm bell, he realized that the sunlight that had been beating down fiercely only moments ago had vanished.

Whoooooosh.

Dark clouds?

No. The dark clouds he knew did not move this fast or hang so low.

A strange sound reached him. As the darkness drew nearer, he finally saw what it was.

“…Goddamn it.”

The dark cloud—or rather, countless flying beasts that had flown in and dyed a section of the vast sky black—descended upon him.

Whoooooosh!

Flap, flap, flap!

He could tell neither how many there were nor what kinds. Sharp cries, flashing beaks, and flying feathers filled the air.

The flying beasts, transformed into one enormous monster, swept through five watchtowers like a storm.

No. They smashed them apart.

CRACK! CRUNCH!

“The watchtower’s coming down!”

“AAAAARGH!”

Charging together, the birds were a living battering ram.

The world tilted. For an instant, the warriors felt themselves floating. Then they fell with the shattered watchtowers.

Rumble, rumble, rumble! Daaang!

An alarm bell nearly as large as a grown man hit the ground first and rolled. The warriors twisted in midair and landed after it, stumbling but upright.

Panting, they raised their heads. A vast shadow fell over them.

“Where is Baeksang?”

“…!”

The quiet voice bored into their ears. Yet everyone there felt a chill that seemed to freeze their hearts.

Was it the enormous White Tiger, so large that looking at it made their knees weak? Or the countless beasts behind it?

No. The White Tiger felt strangely warm and mysterious, and the beasts facing them up close had gentle eyes.

What froze the warriors was the gaze of the man on the White Tiger’s back, looking down at them.

He was tall and perfectly proportioned, with carelessly tousled hair and striking features unlike those of the Nanman people.

And in his hand was a pure-white spear.

“Jin Taekyung!”

At someone’s shriek, the warriors instinctively reached for the weapons at their waists.

They tried to draw them.

At least, they did until Jin Taekyung opened his mouth.

“If you pull those out, you won’t like what happens.”

“…!”

“And if you’ve got eyes, look around. Who else is here besides me?”

Jin Taekyung was the monster blamed for throwing all of Nanman into an uproar. Since he had appeared with an enormous number of beasts, they had thought there could be nothing left to surprise them.

Then they recognized another face.

Step.

A second, smaller White Tiger approached. On its back rode a beautiful woman whose exhaustion did nothing to hide her looks.

“Su-surely not…”

“Great Chieftain Yohi?”

Yohi spoke, her voice clear.

“Do you recognize me?”

How could they not? Every year, when she appeared before the public for the Tribal Grand Council, people packed the streets for a glimpse of her.

But what confused them most was seeing her beside Jin Taekyung, neither afraid nor bound. After the incident at the Western Yao Estate a few days earlier, rumors of her death had spread quietly through Nanman.

And now she was at the head of an immense host of beasts.

“G-Great Chieftain. Why are you with a monster like him…?”

“A monster…”

Yohi muttered quietly and turned her head to look at Jin Taekyung, but Jin Taekyung was not looking at her.

His eyes were fixed on the enormous iron gate separating the Outer Palace from the Inner Palace, at the far end of the road. Something about it felt ominous.

“There comes the monster,” he said.

The next moment, the gate began to open with a heavy grinding sound.

Rumble, rumble, rumble.

Countless arrowheads appeared along the high stone walls of the Inner Palace.

Click, click, click!

Sunlight flashed on their tips. Nearly a thousand archers aimed from the walls, bowstrings drawn taut, their breathing tight with tension.

Then the figure hidden behind the iron gate came into view.

Step.

His footsteps rang out with unusual clarity.

The hem of his spotless white robe brushed the ground. His calm gaze crossed the distance and met one man’s eyes.

“You came. In the end, you did.”

Baeksang.

His voice carried powerful internal energy. Jin Taekyung lowered his spearhead and answered.

“Yes. I came.”

You fucking bastard.

Baeksang.

The moment I saw his face, I felt the internal energy throughout my body boil like lava.

I wanted to charge out immediately.

I wanted to kick off the guardian spirit’s back, race toward him like the wind, and kill him with the fastest, strongest strike I could deliver.

But…

Slick.

A slender finger caught hold of my sleeve. Yohi’s trembling voice reached my ears.

“No. Not yet.”

Yes. I knew that too.

If I cut Baeksang’s head off right now, it would be like lighting the fuse of a bomb with no time left on it.

Baeksang—he could not die like that. He had to die not as the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, but as the traitor and usurper who had deceived all the Nanman people and joined forces with Dark Heaven.

The Palace Lord’s death would bring a brutal battle. But no warrior would fight for a traitor.

It was the only way to spare even a few needless deaths. And Yohi, beside me, was the one person who could expose the truth and stop the battle bearing down on us.

“Let’s go.”

The guardian spirit and Muyaho nodded at my whisper and started forward.

We moved at a steady pace. A thousand arrowheads tracked us, ready to loose a rain of arrows at a single command.

But as we drew closer, their flashing tips began to waver. Taut bowstrings slackened. Unease spread along the Inner Palace walls as the archers recognized Yohi.

There was one exception.

Baeksang.

I stared at his unshaken face.

“The Great Chieftain you used to eat with has come back alive. You could at least ask how she is. Don’t you think?”

Charged with internal energy, my voice carried in every direction.

The unease swelled. Baeksang parted his lips.

“What affection is there between us that I should greet her? We were bound together only by our separate aims.”

“…!”

“…!”

My face stiffened. Yohi’s probably had too.

We were thinking the same thing.

Why?

This was not the Baeksang I knew. He was sly and cunning. His scheming, more frightening than his martial arts, was one of the chief reasons Nanman had fallen into chaos.

Yet he had acknowledged Yohi. In front of everyone who followed him.

My grip tightened around the spear shaft. I clenched my teeth and glared at him.

“What the hell is this…? What kind of bullshit are you pulling?”

“Did you think I would deny it?”

Baeksang turned to look behind him.

Beyond the wide-open gate, countless Nanman warriors stood amid a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords. They and the archers on the walls stared at him, eyes wide.

“What more is there to say? Everything you know—and everything they will soon realize—is true.”

“…!”

“Yes. That is correct.”

Baeksang looked away from his warriors and up at the sky.

Not a cloud marred it. Hot sunlight fell across his face.

“I betrayed everyone.”

His quiet voice, charged with internal energy, broke the suffocating silence that had settled over the area.

It traveled on the air, pierced through the wind, crossed the broad road running through the Outer Palace, passed over the stone walls of the Inner Palace, and reached everyone.

“I lived each day as though it were ten years. To achieve one goal, I became an unforgivable turncoat. And at last, I came this far.”

My breath caught.

This was not a confession in which he admitted the sins he had committed and begged for forgiveness.

No. It was…

Relief that it was over. And despair.

Something altogether different from giving up.

Baeksang was letting out what he had held down every day for decades. He made no attempt to hide his despair, even though he had achieved the goal he had wanted for so long.

No way.

A thought flashed through my mind like lightning. Every hair on my body stood on end.

Then a scream burst from my lips.

“Everyone, fall back—!”

And the next moment—

Rumble, rumble, rumble! Flash!

Thunder shook Heaven and Earth. Dark clouds spread over everyone’s heads.

In a world where not even a single ray of sunlight could be found, someone’s voice bored into my ears.

“What a shame. It’s already too late.”

Chapter 697

“What a shame. It’s already too late.”

A languid voice reached my ears. No—not just mine. Everyone here could hear it.

It heralded the arrival of someone fatally alluring, and more dangerous still.

“The Southern Heaven Demon Empress!”

I whipped my head around at the thunderous shout. Above the heads of everyone frozen by her sudden appearance, billowing robes fluttered atop a pavilion that rose high into the sky.

The catlike eyes looking down at us curved into half-moons.

“Oh my. Who could this be?”

The woman’s face was unfamiliar. Her voice and the feeling she gave me were not.

I knew it was her. I forced the words out through clenched teeth.

“It’s me, you fucking bitch.”

Heat churned in my gut as if I’d swallowed lava. My fingers trembled around the spear shaft, and my heart hammered against my ribs.

A tidal wave of emotion raged through me—far more fiercely than when I had faced Baeksang.

But simple hostility and anger were not the only things that had seized me.

She’s strong.

Was she always this strong?

Just meeting her eyes made my heart sink.

Several months had passed since the incident in Hubei Province. The insights I’d gained since then let me glimpse a little more of my opponent’s true nature. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress standing before me was a greater monster than I had imagined.

No one else here could even guess at her realm. Yet my eyes and sharpened senses could trace the power she concealed: the ferocity behind her gently curved eyes, the immense darkness coiled within her slender frame.

“You fucking bitch.”

“Ahaha! Just as I expected. Just as I expected!”

Whatever amused her so much, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress clutched her stomach and laughed despite the insult. Then she smiled at me.

“You’re so refreshingly straightforward. That’s why I like you, Benefactor.”

“What?”

“Have you forgotten already? Who saved me that day, on cold Dongting Lake, with corpses floating in the water?”

“…!”

As if I could forget. I'd thought back on that moment and regretted it countless times.

Was it because I'd saved the Southern Heaven Demon Empress with my own hands?

No. The person I'd saved that day was Honglan.

In Hubei, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had been nothing more than a beautiful singing courtesan favored by some idiot from the Huang tribe. She had approached me deliberately from the start, and she would have survived even if I hadn't come.

The one thing I regretted was being too stupid to recognize the culprit standing right in front of me.

My anger at myself for failing to realize I had been toyed with for someone else's amusement.

And my guilt at failing to prevent an even greater sacrifice.

Rustle.

"Now I can finally greet you properly."

Honglan—no, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—lifted her billowing robes and dipped her head.

"This lowly woman, Honglan, greets her Benefactor."

I thrust out a palm as fast as lightning.

Fwoosh!

Moisture evaporated in an instant. The force of the Flame Divine Palm, carrying terrible heat, reached her in a heartbeat.

But—

Slice!

In even less time, the powerful palm force—one Baeksang himself would have struggled to stop—was split in two like tofu.

Boom!

Beneath the dark clouds that now covered the sky, the two halves flew off course and exploded in midair.

Cries of shock rose around us.

"W-what was that?"

"D-did you see what I just saw? That woman…"

"The Southern Heaven Demon Empress. Someone definitely called her the Southern Heaven Demon Empress."

Some here knew that title. Others didn't. It hardly mattered. Soon they would all know who she was—and how much viciousness and terrifying power that monster had kept hidden.

I stared coldly at the edge of the pavilion. Standing there, straightening her disheveled court robes, was a woman far too beautiful to be called a monster.

“Hmm. I went to the trouble of being polite, but I don’t much like the way you answered my greeting. Still, I’ll be generous and let it pass. I do owe you my life. I can’t gouge out my Benefactor’s eyes just yet.”

I could feel the killing intent beneath her innocent tone. If anything, it made me calmer.

“Shut your fucking maw.”

“What rough language. A *maw* is something a beast has. For example…”

Her voice trailed off as her gaze shifted slightly downward, toward the enormous White Tiger baring its teeth.

“Yes. That word suits that hideous beast perfectly.”

Grrrrr.

The guardian spirit growled low and glared at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. I could feel its muscles tense as it prepared itself.

“A hideous beast, you say. Then what should a human like you be called?”

Until now, its thoughts had been much like Sound Transmission. This time, its voice reached everyone.

The warriors surrounding the Inner Palace, inside and out, caught their breath. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress widened her eyes, then gave a quiet laugh and looked at me.

“I stand corrected. It’s not merely hideous. It’s an interesting beast, too.”

“I don’t know about that.”

I tightened my grip on the spear. Dozens of movements and forms flashed through my mind—ways to end her life with the fastest, deadliest strike I could deliver.

“You’ll find it even more interesting in a moment. This one’s going to bite through the back of your neck.”

“A beast is still a beast. The same was true of a certain foolish imugi that waited for Heaven’s call.”

“He was not foolish. He was kind. Kind enough to sacrifice his life and the cultivation he had built over hundreds of years.”

The guardian spirit fixed its blue-white eyes on her as though it could see straight through her.

“I know you.”

A faint smile touched her lips.

“That’s hardly welcome news. I have no interest in a beast that reeks like you do.”

“I saw you in the imugi’s memories. A human, endlessly dark and filled with malice.”

“Memories?”

“Everything that makes up the world possesses an essence and traces. And in that sense, you in its memories were…”

“Beautiful, I suppose. Dazzlingly so.”

“Old and hideous. So much so that it was hard to believe you were human.”

“…!”

“That is your essence. You have denied and hated your true form, clinging to life through the long years. You are no different from a Fiend.”

Silence followed the guardian spirit’s words. The people who had been murmuring in shock fell quiet. The countless growling beasts held their breath and lowered themselves to the ground.

And at the center of it all stood one person.

Fwoosh!

The sleeves of her court robes swelled as though they might burst. A terrifying surge of qi pressed down in every direction with the weight of a mountain, freezing every living thing in place.

Crack. Crack.

The wind stopped. The pavilion roof began to collapse under the pressure.

“…Is that so?”

Her smile was gone. Her darkened eyes looked down on the world below.

“Old and hideous. Yes. So that’s what I am.”

She spoke calmly, then turned to stare at me.

“I’ll give you credit for making it this far. If you’d arrived a day earlier—no, even half a day—I couldn’t have guaranteed the outcome myself.”

Her tone had changed. So had the air around her.

Yet I felt calmer. People were most frightening when they kept their true nature hidden. Once they lost the smile and composure they’d held on to until the end, an opening appeared.

Besides…

I still had a card up my sleeve. A move I could make even if the worst happened, as long as I had the strength to use it.

That was why I could speak.

“Hmm. I’m genuinely curious about something.”

Just like this.

“How ugly is your face, really, for someone to say something like that to you?”

“…!”

“Were you a mortar in your past life?”

The next moment—

“I’ll make you regret that.”

Her cold voice broke the brief silence. Dark clouds swallowed the sky.

And then…

Fwoosh!

A mass of pitch-black light poured from the enormous cliff behind the Inner Palace.

That's…

The sight alone made it hard to breathe.

It was a *rift*.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The earth shook. The world shook. With a deafening roar, the enormous cliff that had stood there for hundreds—no, thousands—of years began to split apart.

"Ah. Ahhh…"

Someone groaned in shock at the strange, terrifying sight.

So it has come to this. At long last.

Someone else spat out a despairing mutter in the depths of their heart.

"It's over. All of it."

And someone who had been consumed by anger watched what they had brought about with rapture in their eyes.

At last. At last!

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress trembled, already forgetting the anger she had felt moments before.

How could she not? This was the fruit of long years of endurance.

That rift, far larger and more powerful than the one in Hubei Province, was her creation. It marked the moment the omnipotent Lord of Heaven's will descended upon this land.

Kraaaaaaash!

A blade-sharp gale swept in every direction. Through the widening gap in the cliff, an intensely dark and viscous energy began to crawl out, gnawing away at the world.

Demonic qi that would corrupt life and conquer this land!

—Krrk, krrrk!

—Kyaaaaa!

"Ghk. Guhk!"

"W-what's happening all of a sudden—krrk!"

The rift had not even opened completely, yet its power was already spreading in every direction.

Look at that surging darkness. At the countless beasts and humans writhing with the whites of their eyes showing, awaiting the change to come.

And soon, the change caused by the rift would begin.

No. That's not right.

This was not change. It was *evolution*.

They would be reborn as stronger, more beautiful beings. It was a blessing the omnipotent Lord of Heaven bestowed upon lowly creatures.

A lingering smile spread across the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's lips. Then her gaze fell on one person.

Jin Taekyung.

A young man stood tall, staring at the unbelievable, overwhelming spectacle unfolding before him.

To the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, he looked absurd—and pitiful. Enough to make her want to rip his throat out in one go.

You… should never have come here.

She was about to launch herself toward Jin Taekyung when—

Fwoosh!

A tremendous radiance burst forth from somewhere and swallowed the darkness.

Chapter 698

What is that?

The question filled the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's mind. Her eyes widened.

Light.

Bigger and brighter than any light she had ever seen.

A tremendous radiance that had erupted without warning swelled as though it might burst, swallowing the approaching darkness as it seeped into the world.

Kwooooooo!

A pillar of light shot toward the distant sky and pierced the heavens. Sunlight poured through a gap in the dark clouds.

The darkness that had surged over the stone walls like a wave faltered the moment it touched the radiance, as though its path had been blocked.

Blocked? Even the demonic qi summoned from the rift?

It was impossible to believe.

The rift's demonic qi was immensely powerful, a force of pure darkness. Even the imugi[2991], after hundreds of years of cultivation, had been unable to withstand its full power and had fallen to corruption.

Yet the scene before her was real.

The dark clouds were slowly scattering.

The wave of darkness could advance no farther against the radiance.

And then—

"Wow. This really works."

"…!"

Jin Taekyung stood at the center of the radiance, grinning at her.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress clenched her teeth.

"How… How in the world?"

Before she could finish, Jin Taekyung shrugged.

"No big deal. Everyone's got a divine artifact stashed away somewhere, right?"

"…!"

Divine artifact.

The words struck her like a hammer to the back of the head.

Only then did her gaze slide away from Jin Taekyung and settle on another being.

That beast.

[2991] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with the prospect of becoming a dragon.

The enormous White Tiger had its jaws open as if roaring. Like the imugi[2992] she had corrupted, it was clearly more than a spiritual creature.

Through the dazzling radiance, she could faintly make out something shining with a clear, luminous glow.

At the same time, an ancient legend of this land flashed through her mind.

"…The Beast King Stone."

The words slipped between her pomegranate-red lips. Jin Taekyung gave a quiet laugh.

"Oh. You know it?"

How could she not?

The symbol of the king before whom every beast in the world bowed. Nanman's divine artifact, lost for hundreds of years.

No, she could hardly have failed to recognize it. She was the one who had combed every inch of Nanman's rugged terrain for the Beast King Stone.

For more than ten years.

Yet even after enough time had passed for mountains and rivers to change, she had failed to find so much as the slightest trace of the Beast King Stone itself. In the end, she had left the ancient legend behind and begun her grand plan.

But why? Why now?

"You bastaaaaards!"

Whoooooosh! Crack!

A terrifyingly immense surge of qi rose and pressed down on everything around it.

The countless beasts that had been baring their teeth and growling tucked their tails between their legs. Pavilions throughout the area began to collapse as though a giant had stepped on them.

Tribespeople fleeing the Outer Palace in terror spotted the figure suspended in the air and gaped.

"A-Ah…!"

Darkness.

A woman wrapped from head to toe in surging darkness looked down upon the ground.

Like a god—or a Fiend out of legend—she seemed to be weighing how much life they had left.

Yet while everyone else stared at her in fear, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had eyes for only one thing.

"Hand it over."

[2992] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with the prospect of becoming a dragon.

Rumble.

The dark clouds filling the sky gave a great roar.

Her chilling voice rang through the world of light and darkness, reaching every ear.

“It is something the Lord of Heaven must rightfully take. It is not an object that insignificant beings like you are fit to possess.”

Beasts and humans alike froze before her overwhelming power. They forgot to scream, forgot to run, and stared blankly up at her.

All except two people.

No—two beings.

“Bullshit, you crazy bitch.”

—How dare a mere human covet the sacred stone?

Jin Taekyung and the guardian spirit stared at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

They could feel it: the unprecedented power coiled inside that small body.

The qi pressing down around them was greater than any the guardian spirit had encountered in a human over the past several hundred years. It surpassed even that of the Western Heaven Demon Lord, whom Jin Taekyung had fought while narrowly escaping death time and again.

Strong.

And frightening.

Fear was something every living creature knew. But feeling it and surrendering to it were different things.

They knew that even now, they had to endure the fear pressing down on their entire bodies and advance. Only then could they win.

—Much blood will flow, human.

“Fuck. If I survive this, I won’t even take a piss toward Nanman again.”

Jin Taekyung muttered through clenched teeth and tightened his grip on White Flame’s shaft.

Then he spoke quietly to Yohi, who stood frozen behind him.

“You know what to do, right?”

“…!”

“Get the people out of here. Now. Run like hell, and take them as far away as you can.”

Countless tribespeople lived in the Outer Palace, beyond those he could see.

Jin Taekyung did not want them caught in the horrific hellscape about to unfold here.

It was enough for those with power to bleed. The tribespeople, with neither weapons nor sharp teeth, had to survive.

Even if everyone who remained here died at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's hands.

But… I'll stop her. We'll stop her.

For now, the sacred stone's power was holding back the demonic qi pouring from the rift.

He did not know how long this tense standoff would last, but before the situation grew any worse, they had to defeat the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and close the rift.

No matter what it takes.

Whoosh.

Jin Taekyung drew a deep breath and glared at the figure high above the wreckage of the pavilions.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress. The beginning and end of everything that had happened in this land.

Someone had to fall before this cruel story could end.

"Let's go."

The low voice had just slipped between his lips when—

—Kraaaaaaang!

A fierce roar tore through the wind.

The radiance that had been fading against the darkness swelled once more, rousing the terrified beasts and people.

Fwoosh! Kwooooooosh!

Light burst forth with the roar. Flames blazed around the silver spearhead.

The outsider who had come to this land after hundreds of years soared upward as one with the enormous White Tiger.

Bang!

He kicked off the ground.

Pop!

He stepped on the invisible air and wind.

Whooooooosh!

Toward the darkness spread across the distant sky.

No.

Toward the being made still stronger by that darkness.

"Southern Heaven Demon Empress!"

His flame-wreathed azure dragon's roar flew with the spearhead, cleaving through space.

A chilling look crossed the woman's face, now twisted like a Fiend's, with not a trace of beauty left.

"The Lord of Heaven desires it."

At that moment—

Flash!

Light and darkness mingled in a blinding flash that washed over the Nanman Beast Palace.

Rrrrrumble.

A roar like the sky splitting apart accompanied a tremendous surge of qi that swept in every direction.

Baeksang instinctively shut his eyes against the blinding flash. A gale struck his entire body, and he swallowed a groan.

Hngh.

What kind of overwhelming power was this?

Even as a Supreme Peak master, he could barely keep his balance against the aftershock.

When he finally opened his eyes, the area around him had already been reduced to ruins. The tribespeople who had barely survived thanks to the protection of the beasts were fleeing while screaming.

"Kyaaaaaa!"

"Hoya! Hoya! Where are you?"

"M-Mother!"

Pavilions and houses built over many years collapsed one after another. A grown son cried out at the sight of his elderly mother pinned beneath a fallen stone wall.

Screams and death. Blood and bodies.

Only days ago, these streets had been full of laughter and music. Now there was no trace of either—only an endless din of roars and screams.

Bang! Kwoooooang!

Light and darkness shot toward each other and tangled together, again and again, in the space of an instant.

Baeksang stared hollowly at the hellscape beneath the murky flashes and sky-splitting roars. Then he reached out in one direction.

Boom!

The force of his palm crossed the distance and knocked a large boulder away.

A half-gray-haired middle-aged man who had been struggling to save an old woman trapped beneath the stone wall widened his eyes.

"Y-You…"

Something about the man's face was familiar. Perhaps they had met somewhere.

Baeksang watched him help the old woman up, anger and gratitude mingling on his face. Then he saw her face and understood.

He looks like her. So much.

It was the old palace attendant he had personally ordered expelled from the Inner Palace before any of this began.

One of the few people left who remembered the man he had once been was bleeding and groaning before him.

"Cough. Mmm…"

"M-Mother!"

She had a child?

Baeksang watched the man hurriedly check on his mother, then found himself walking toward them.

He did not know why. He simply felt that he should.

"D-Don't come any closer!"

The cry was full of hostility.

People could shut their doors and lock them, but they could not close their ears.

By now, everyone in the Nanman Beast Palace knew their Palace Lord, the Great Chieftain of the Bai people, had betrayed them. They knew Baeksang was responsible for the screams and deaths that continued even now.

The man before him knew it too. He stood between Baeksang and his mother, clutching a sharp piece of stone he had picked up somewhere.

"If you take one more step…"

Swish! Crack!

Finger Qi pierced the stone, and it crumbled in his hand.

Baeksang passed the frozen man and reached toward the old woman.

Tap. Tap!

The blurred hand moved like lightning, touching the old woman's acupoints. At the same moment, her furrowed brow smoothed.

"Cough."

She spat out stagnant blood, and her face relaxed.

The man hastily checked his mother, then looked up at Baeksang, unable to understand.

"W-Why?"

Why?

Baeksang could not answer even that simple question. Perhaps he would not be able to answer it in ten years, or a hundred.

He did not know the answer himself.

When he finally broke the brief silence, he gave no answer.

“Leave with the others. Get as far away as you can.”

“S-Sir!”

“Do you intend to let your mother die like this? Or…”

Baeksang’s gaze darkened.

“Will you make her watch you die?”

“…!”

“Go. If you head for the East Gate, a way out will open.”

Baeksang turned away. Behind him, the man’s hoarse voice rang out.

“Do you think this will… Do you think this will make the sins you committed forgivable!”

Baeksang answered the angry shout only in his heart.

No. I never once thought I would be forgiven.

Rumble, rumble!

A deafening roar rolled behind him as he headed toward the Inner Palace.

He sped onward without a trace of hesitation.

It was time to face the moment he had pictured for decades.

Chapter 699

Rumble! Crash!

Unable to withstand the fierce vibrations, the stone walls of the Inner Palace crumbled helplessly, and the iron gate that had broken free slammed into the ground with a heavy roar.

It was like watching a small hill collapse.

Baeksang slipped past the debris and shot forward.

Whoooosh!

Wind brushed across his entire body. His sharpened senses caught the metallic scent of blood and the screams echoing from every direction.

He felt the internal energy churning inside him and took a deep breath.

I must not let it overwhelm me.

A massive cliff rose behind the Inner Palace like a folding screen. Demonic qi flowed from a gap in it—a gap that could only be called a *rift* now. Even Baeksang could not take it lightly.

Only because he was a Supreme Peak master could he move through the Inner Palace like this. Unless one walked the Demonic Path, even a fairly skilled internal-energy master would have had his internal energy thrown into disarray and lost his composure the moment he entered the demonic qi's domain.

Just like the middle-aged man now staggering into his path to block him.

"P-Palace Lord? Is that you, Palace Lord?"

Baeksang knew his face. Greedy like his father, the man had inherited his position as tribal chieftain without any particular ability and lived in luxury. He had been one of Baeksang's most ardent supporters.

But the man who used to greet Baeksang with an oily, flattering smile was now crying out with blood running from his seven apertures.[2993]

"Please, please save me! I don't want to die ye—!"

His flailing hand brushed Baeksang's white collar. Baeksang quietly looked down at the fallen tribal chieftain, who had lost his balance, and opened his mouth.

"Why should I?"

"P-Palace Lord?"

"You must have known already. That what I intended to do would bring great harm to Nanman."

"…!"

"We each got what we wanted and paid a fair price for it. So don't think you've been wronged."

[2993] The "seven apertures" are the two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth.

I won't, either.

The last words never left his lips. Finger Qi shot from his fingertips.

Puhk!

The attack pierced the crown of the chieftain's skull, and he collapsed. His eyes remained wide with disbelief. Even in death, they seemed to ask Baeksang a question.

Why? How? How can you still stand so proudly even in the face of this hellscape?

And Baeksang answered the dead man's question in his heart.

Because I had already made up my mind.

Even so, his breath trembled.

If that man had begged him to save the tribespeople instead of his own life, would Baeksang have saved them?

No. Perhaps meeting such a peaceful death was actually an act of mercy for a man with such poor martial arts.

Ten thousand.

A full ten thousand warriors and beasts were bleeding and writhing in the grip of the demonic qi. Their screams seemed to squeeze his heart and rake through his mind like blades.

Baeksang did not stop.

Whoooosh!

He sped across the vast training ground, where screams filled the air. The stable where he and Yayul Cheok had hidden whenever they got into trouble as children flashed past, then the storehouse they used to sneak into for fruit wine.

Vengeance. Anger. Regret.

The emotions that had piled up layer after layer with every step whipped around him.

If only I hadn't taken my only son to the battlefield. If only I'd drawn my sword instead of clasping hands with the Southern Heaven Demon Empress the day she came.

If only I'd told my one sworn elder brother the whole truth. He'd trusted me more than anyone—even more than I trusted myself.

Or…

If only I'd carried it all alone and taken my own life.

Step.

His feet stopped before a tightly closed door. His eyes had long since gone bloodshot.

In his mind, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's voice echoed from the night before.

"Noon. Tomorrow at noon. Gather every warrior in the palace at the Inner Palace."

“Tomorrow… at noon?”

“Yes. That’s the end of your part. After that, we’ll take care of—”

“Our promise.”

“Hmm?”

“Please keep the promise you made me long ago.”

“You’re rather impudent, aren’t you? Interrupting an adult while she’s speaking.”

She had laughed. Baeksang had dropped to his knees without hesitation.

Only after watching the new lord of the Nanman Beast Palace repeatedly strike his head against the floor for quite some time did she finally give him the answer he had so desperately wanted.

“A polite child deserves a reward. Fine. Once the grand plan begins, return to your office.”

“My… office?”

“Yes. This very place. That’s when I’ll fulfill my promise.”

Her amused voice faded from his ears. Baeksang’s only hand trembled as he reached toward the door, slowly, so slowly.

He had never wondered *how*. If the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and Dark Heaven said it was so, then it was so. All the things they had done—things that seemed to defy nature—made it easier still to believe.

However many eyes watched the Inner Palace, the promise would be kept.

At last.

He had made it here.

Baeksang closed his eyes. A wave of distant memories rose and swallowed him.

Long years of suffering.

But even this lonely story had a final chapter. He opened his eyes as though waking from sleep and pushed the door wide.

Creak.

His spacious office came into view.

Simple, crude furnishings that still held the warmth of their former owner. A table that had preserved the traces of many long years.

And, out of place among them, a large mirror.

And then. And then…

That was all.

Nothing. There’s nothing here.

The impossible truth bore down on him like a massive boulder. Baeksang stared at the office with hollow, empty eyes, then suddenly let out a hollow laugh.

“Heh. Heh heh. Heh heh heh.”

He laughed because he could not cry. Because he could do nothing else.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress had not kept her promise. Decades of his life, everything he had done—all of it turned to ash and blew away.

So this was how it ended.

“Ha-ha-ha-ha-ha!”

Baeksang laughed as though he were a boy again. He clutched his stomach and rolled across the floor, tears streaming down his face.

No. He was crying.

“Ha—ha-ha! Aaaaaah!”

The laughter broke into a scream. Baeksang struck the floor and walls with a fist that held not a trace of internal energy.

Bang! Bang! Krrr-boom!

He kept punching. The office was not the only thing that broke.

The callused back of his hand split open, and white bone showed faintly through the blood covering his fist.

It hurts.

More than it ever had.

Drip. Drip-drip.

Blood pooled in the spiderweb cracks across the floor. Baeksang staggered to his feet and approached the window.

He had thought the world had stopped. Beyond the open window, everything was still moving at a furious pace.

“Graaah!”

“P-Please, just kill me…!”

—Grrk, grrrk!

Humans and beasts struggled as they resisted the demonic qi devouring their bodies and minds. Shapes large and small raced toward them as they screamed.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Countless beasts thundered across the ground, climbed over the collapsed stone walls, and descended upon them—not to kill, but to rescue them.

—Graaaar!

With the roar of a familiar White Tiger at the head of the group, the beasts moved in perfect formation. They bit the arms, legs, or scruffs of the nearest people and beasts, then raced toward the Outer Palace.

Away from the demonic qi. One step farther toward the light.

Baeksang clenched his fist. His nails dug into his palm, and blood welled around them.

He looked into the distance, where light and darkness clashed without pause.

Rumble!

He could feel waves of unimaginable power. With every clash, the light faded a little more, and one figure fell again.

Boom! Crack!

The figure hurtled toward the ground like a meteor. Two pavilions collapsed, and the earth shook.

But only for a moment. Blue flames stepped on empty air and shot toward the thick darkness.

Without a moment's rest. As though it could burn away even the death waiting for it.

Jin Taekyung.

Why go so far? Why?

The question remained trapped in Baeksang's mouth. Another question, heard not long ago in a corner of a dark underground prison, echoed in his ears.

"How much more blood do you mean to spill, Baeksang?"

Baeksang stared blankly out the window and finally gave his answer.

"I don't know. I don't know either."

It was a secret he had been unable to tell anyone.

After losing his son, he had dreamed of revenge. Meeting the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had given him hope. Then one day he had realized he'd crossed a river he could never cross back, and despair had followed.

And now, at the end of the thorny path he had walked, he found nothing at all.

Step.

Baeksang staggered back from the window. He could no longer bear to watch the hellscape he had made with his own hands, or the young outsider risking his life to stop it from becoming complete.

What was any of it for?

He turned away from the window with a question he would never answer—and froze.

"…!"

Someone covered in blood and dust was looking back at him.

A man who had lost everything and become an empty shell. An old man who had held the years at bay through sheer martial power, surviving as a monster.

The large mirror occupying one corner of the office reflected his figure.

But Baeksang saw something else, too.

"Ah."

Hwi.

He reached toward him with a call that could never reach him. Or tried to.

The mirror's clear, smooth surface rippled like water.

Ssssrrrk.

Only then did Baeksang understand who had given him the mirror, and why the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had said her promise would be fulfilled here.

She hadn't lied.

In his cold heart, an ember of hope he had thought extinguished began to burn again.

The mirror clouded with darkness. Before Baeksang's trembling eyes, it spat out a black-clad figure—and a cold sword blade imbued with Force.

Puhk!

Flash.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress thrust out a foot smaller than a boy's palm.

The moment it met the side of my spearhead, a force greater than a giant's surged through me.

Crack—bang!

"Human!"

I heard the guardian spirit's cry as I fell. The impact drove me deep into the ground and jolted through my back, forcing my mouth open.

Cough.

Blood ran from the corner of my mouth. I'd already suffered serious Internal Injury, and my cracked bones creaked and ached whenever I moved.

Monster.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress was a bitch for the ages, and a monster to match. Her martial arts surpassed anyone I'd faced—even the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

But…

Get up. As many times as it takes.

A few times. A few dozen. It didn't matter.

There was nowhere left to retreat. If I took even one step back, that place would become hell.

Not only me, but every living thing in Nanman—and even the Central Plains—would inevitably be swallowed by the flames.

I have to stop her.

I wiped the blood from the corner of my mouth with my sleeve and stood.

Before I could summon my internal energy again, I realized things could still get worse.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

I turned my head on instinct.

“…Fuck.”

Darkness descending thickly over the collapsing Inner Palace.

Chapter 700

Me, the guardian spirit, and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Less than fifteen minutes had passed since the battle began, but if I was being generous, we'd been evenly matched.

Until now.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

"…Fuck."

The curse slipped out before I could stop it.

Not just because the Inner Palace was collapsing. It might have been the symbol and pride of the Nanman Beast Palace, but in the end, it was only a building.

The problem was that as the largest structure in the Nanman Beast Palace crumbled like a sandcastle, the darkness pouring from the rift grew thicker.

Kraaaaaash!

Demonic qi. Also known as magical power.

That pure, dangerous energy surged outward in a wave. It swallowed the enormous dust cloud, crossed the open space, and reached the living beings who had yet to escape the Inner Palace.

"Grrk, keugh!"

—Kyaaaaaa!

Humans and beasts screamed.

The eyes that had begun to regain focus turned white. Their trembling bodies contorted with a sickening sound of tearing flesh.

Crack. Crrrunch.

Death flashed through my mind, but that wasn't it.

What awaited them was pain worse than death, and the changes that would soon come over them would make them forget even the pain.

No. I should call it a mutation, not a change.

I knew what I was seeing. I'd seen it once before—and experienced it myself.

The magical power from the rift had been strong enough to corrupt a five-hundred-year-old imugi. The Water God Dragon had borne it alone, so its case was different. Even so, ordinary beasts and most martial artists had no hope of shaking off its influence by themselves.

Not unless someone helped them.

And apparently, that someone is me.

Fuck.

I hesitated at the thought of leaving the guardian spirit to fight alone, but only for a moment.

Several thousand humans and beasts were still inside the Inner Palace. Their lives were reason enough. But if the magical power consumed them completely and turned them into mutants, the hellscape the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had envisioned would be complete.

Whatever else happened, a horrific slaughter would begin as they killed one another.

In a moment too short to call an instant, I wasn't the only one to realize it.

—Go! Hurry!

The thought rang through my head almost at the same time I kicked off the ground.

Boom!

Compression. Then explosion.

A violent wind struck my body, and the scenery changed around me.

I shot forward like a cannonball, leaving a small crater behind and clearing more than sixty yards in a single bound. As my toes touched down lightly, flames of manifested qi flickered beneath them.

Flamefire Path.

Kraaaaaash!

In a world gone slow, blue-white light-flames burst forth.

The guardian spirit vanished from my sight as it charged the Southern Heaven Demon Empress with a roar that shook the sky. So did Muyaho, racing out of the Outer Palace with all his strength at the very rear of the survivors.

Whoooosh.

Wind carrying the scent of blood brushed across my entire body. By then, beneath the feet I had planted in midair, I could see countless beasts and humans writhing as darkness engulfed them.

And…

I can feel it.

After reaching the Supreme Peak realm, each new insight had taught me the same thing: everything in the world had a flow. Just because I couldn't see it didn't mean I couldn't feel it.

The formless wind. Rock hard enough to turn aside steel. Still water. Each had its flow, or a faint gap within it.

Its grain.

Now!

Fwoooosh!

Certain of my aim, I slashed downward with my spear.

[2994] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi represent 180 years of internal energy.

Three jiazi[2994] of Scorching Yang Qi coiled around its transparent blade, burning through the darkness as it cut through the air.

I aimed for the grain in the pitch-black darkness wrapped around thousands of lives. For that fine, invisible flow I could sever in a single stroke.

And then—

Whoooosh—boom!

A roar like the sky splitting apart rang out as flames streaming from White Flame's blade exploded in a brilliant burst.

"…!"

My eyes widened.

The battles had left me exhausted and injured, but that strike had been nearly everything I had. I'd been sure I could scatter at least some of the demonic qi, if not all of it.

And he knocked it away?

I'd seen it clearly, brief as it was: Force flying out of the darkness like a ray of light. Though it was far too dark and ominous to deserve the name.

Tap.

I landed softly and glared into the darkness.

No—at the hazy figure walking slowly out of the Inner Palace ruins, half-hidden by the dust.

"…A mask? Who the fuck are you?"

The answer to my question was a single flash of light that glinted from more than thirty yards away.

Shwaaaak! Slash!

I missed it by a hair.

I twisted my head like lightning and glanced over my shoulder. A pavilion that had somehow retained its shape until now had been crushed and split in half.

Crack. Rumble!

Watching the pavilion collapse half a beat late, I muttered inwardly.

Fast.

The power behind that attack was savage and unrefined. Rough, yes—but devastating. If I failed to dodge even once, there wouldn't be enough of my body left to find.

But the same was true of me.

Puhk. Whoooosh!

I didn't need to summon anything from my Inventory. Weapons lay scattered everywhere. I pulled an iron spear from the ground, took it in a reverse grip, and hurled it with all my strength.

Boom!

Force stopped the spear and sent it bouncing away. Just as I'd expected.

I'd launched myself forward the instant I threw it. Now I drove White Flame at the masked man.

Shu-whoom! Boom!

Compressed air burst from the spearpoint. The masked man twisted aside by no more than a sheet of paper's width, seized the shaft, and stepped in.

At the same time, dark sword-light flashed from his fingertips.

Slash!

A faint sting.

I'd dodged, but not quite enough. Wind from the powerful sword strike grazed the bridge of my nose, drawing blood.

A few drops were cheap. I was about to get far more in return.

If you think I'm like other martial artists, you've got it wrong.

Martial artists valued their weapons as much as their lives. Most trained in arts that used them, knowing a few clumsy fist, palm, finger, or kicking techniques wouldn't see them through a life-and-death duel.

I was different.

I had physical abilities beyond human limits and the Fire Gate Clan's fist, palm, finger, and kicking techniques—arts worthy of being called divine. I also had an Inventory with nearly limitless capacity, full of weapons.

Crack!

Even a divine weapon was useless if it couldn't reach its target.

I let go of the spear shaft, caught the wrist of his sword hand, and shot out my free hand. At the same time, I gave a command only I could understand.

Inventory open. Summon.

Whoosh!

I missed his heart, but the rusty dagger, glowing red with Scorching Yang Qi, pierced Body-Protecting Qi harder than armor and sank into his chest.

Puhk!

"…!"

He went rigid without so much as a groan.

I wasn't stopping there.

Finish him.

I didn't know his name or sobriquet. I did know he served the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. If I held back and let him live, I'd pay for it.

He had to die here. Now.

Crack! Crunch!

Still gripping his wrist, I drove my knee up like lightning and felt his bones shatter. The arm with the crushed elbow went limp, and his sword began to slip from his fingers.

Srrk.

One of those fingers twitched.

From a blind spot I couldn't see came the sound of something slicing through the air.

Whoooosh!

Everything had a grain and a flow. So did the sounds weapons made.

What is that?

I'd heard it somewhere before. The recognition was almost there, along with a sharp sense that something was wrong, but I had no time to follow it.

Only an instant to choose.

Trust my instincts and the Fire Dragon Armor, and finish him? Or leave him with the grievous wounds he'd already taken and protect myself?

I made my choice. Turning, I thrust out my hand.

No—both palms.

One toward the masked man. The other toward the two streaks of light already upon me.

Boom! Crash!

The Flame Divine Palm struck his chest and sent him flying like a cannonball into the ruins of the Inner Palace.

But…

Crrrunch!

Had I been too greedy, trying to catch two birds at once?

The impact drove me backward. I carved a deep furrow into the ground for ten steps before the burning pain reached me.

Tap. Drip-drip.

Blood ran down my fingers and struck the ground. I staunched the bleeding from my left hand, its flesh and muscle torn half to shreds, then bit my lip.

Because it hurt? No. I'd taken injuries like this often enough as a Hunter.

An injured hand was bad news when I needed to conserve every bit of strength I could, but I could still use it.

It was the tremendous rebound force I had felt when my Flame Divine Palm struck the masked man's chest—and the identity of the flash whose sound alone had caused that sense of incongruity.

This is…

The shape and size were different, but I knew what I was holding.

I stared at the twin wheels caught in my left hand and slowly turned, thinking of the old fiend whose last words had been a promise to wait for me in the afterlife.

"What's your connection to the Great Snow Fiend?"

I hoped he wouldn't answer. I hoped the force I'd felt at the end had been my imagination.

But my ominous suspicion had already become reality.

Rumble. Rustle.

Within the cloud of dust that had yet to settle, heavy rebar and timber shifted, and a pale figure rose to its feet.

Then a flashing streak of light crossed more than sixty yards and hurtled at me.

Whoosh! Crrrunch!

It came with ferocious force. I caught it in a hand filled with internal energy and fell silent.

A dagger.

The same dagger I'd driven into his chest moments ago.

Blood that wasn't mine stained its heavily rusted, handspan-long blade. My attack had landed.

If so, he should have suffered a fatal wound… How the hell?

I knew all too well that humans—Supreme Peak masters in particular—didn't die as easily as one might think.

They were monsters capable of fighting a hundred men alone even with a dagger buried in their chest.

But not when the one who put it there was a Supreme Peak master of equal or greater skill.

This isn't a fight between street thugs.

In a life-and-death duel between masters, the greatest danger wasn't the blade. It was the internal energy carried on it—energy that entered through the wound and tore apart the blood vessels within.

Even a Supreme Peak master couldn't escape Internal Injury from a hit like that. The Great Snow Fiend himself, with all his martial arts and profound internal energy, hadn't been an exception.

And yet…

He got up like nothing happened, pulled the dagger out of his chest, and threw it? With this much internal energy behind it, when suppressing the Internal Injury alone should have been a struggle?

The dagger wound wasn't even all he'd taken. One arm was crippled at the very least, and I'd struck him square in the chest with the Flame Divine Palm.

Even a master at the level of the Ten Kings could not be that unharmed.

"…What the fuck are you?"

That wrongness had spread through my whole body, bringing a cold wariness with it.

But before the masked man could answer my question, a tremendous roar rang out.

Kraaa-boom!

A silver figure struck the ground like a meteor.

The guardian spirit lay there, its body covered in wounds, panting for breath.
Above its head in midair, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress stood with a smile.

“My hunting dog. I took great care training him.”

Chapter 701

“My hunting dog. I took great care training him.”

The Southern Heaven Demon Emress’s voice rang out softly. At the same time, the Masked Man took a step forward.

Step.

His stride never faltered as he emerged from the settling cloud of dust.

As the Masked Man’s form gradually came into focus, I muttered like a groan.

“…Fuck. What the hell is that?”

I wasn’t looking for an answer. I already knew.

Regeneration.

That one word explained the bizarre sight unfolding before my eyes.

Crack. Slither.

Shattered bones joined together. Flesh and blood filled the wounds.

Darkness writhed like a living snake across the Masked Man’s body, healing his injuries and pouring new strength into him wherever it passed.

—The power of defying heaven…

Defying heaven.

What I was seeing seemed to run against the will of heaven and the natural order itself.

As the guardian spirit’s lament reached me, the Masked Man finished healing and bent his strangely twisted elbow.

Crunch.

He broke the elbow that had already fused back together, then aligned it and healed it again.

The pain must have been tremendous, yet he didn’t so much as twitch an eyebrow. At last, I understood what had felt wrong about him during our fight.

That bastard can’t feel pain.

Even someone with a dulled sense of pain would feel something.

But the Masked Man hadn’t groaned or screamed once. Not when a dagger lodged in his chest or his elbow was crushed. Not even when the terrible heat of the Flame Divine Palm had struck him.

What the hell did they do to him?

Had he gone somewhere for a painkilling shot?

As I stared at the emotionless eyes visible above his mask and swallowed a low groan, someone’s small, snow-white foot stepped onto the damp earth.

Scuff.

From the sky to the ground. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress landed lightly and smiled.

“You look like you’ve seen a ghost. Then again, I suppose you weren’t all that surprised? You saw it once in Henan.”

Grrr.

With a low growl, the guardian spirit raised its enormous, bloodstained body on weary limbs.

Its breathing was much rougher than it had been at the start. If it fought her now, it would lose. No question.

I stepped in front of the guardian spirit and opened my mouth.

“Yeah. The Blood Lord. That crazy bastard was the same.”

“What a shame. If you hadn’t met the Blood Lord, I could’ve seen you scared out of your wits.”

“If I scared that easily, I’d have died ages ago.”

“Maybe it’s because you’re young. You can’t help the bluffing.”

A bluff.

What the Blood Lord had done during the Shaolin Bloodshed had certainly surprised me. It hadn’t scared me out of my wits.

I’d seen and been through too much in the modern world where I was born and raised.

“Think whatever you want.”

Something in my calm reply made the Southern Heaven Demon Empress draw her brows together. She looked me up and down through narrowed eyes, then licked her red lips.

“I can’t tell if you’re simply brave or if you have something no one else knows about… But there’s something strange about you. I’m beginning to see why the Lord of Heaven takes an interest in you.”

“An interest?”

I began circulating my internal energy, slowly enough that she wouldn’t notice.

She was more than enough of a monster to deal with alone. Now I had a drugged-up bastard who might as well have had a painkilling shot to worry about too. I needed to buy time and heal as much of my Internal Injury as I could.

“The Great Snow Fiend, that old man, spouted the same nonsense.”

“Oh? Do you still think it’s nonsense?”

She smiled and took a step toward me. I tightened my grip on my spear.

“I wish it were.”

“Why?”

“Because I don’t want some deranged old man’s attention, Lord of Heaven or not. Same goes for the crazy bitch standing in front of me.”

Whoosh—pfft!

Pain stung my cheek, and heat spread across it. I'd dodged the Finger Qi by a hair.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress sighed in relief.

"Phew. I nearly killed you. Good dodge. You're better than I thought."

Praise from an enemy, at a time like this.

It pissed me off. It also told me two things.

First, even if that monster went all out, I could handle her attacks if I kept the damage as slight as I had just now.

Second, she had more to lose than gain by killing me.

Blood ran down my cheek. Instead of wiping it away, I tightened my grip on the spear.

"The Lord of Heaven must be more interested in me than I thought. Even a crazy bitch like you is worried about killing me."

"…!"

"I think I'm starting to understand why you only watched me in Hubei Province."

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress was staggeringly powerful. Of everyone I'd ever encountered, very few could stand against her.

At least on the level of the Ten Kings. Maybe higher.

I could feel the sheer force of her power just standing here.

Apart from Jeok Cheongang, who was an exception even among the Ten Kings, she had to be one of the ten strongest people alive.

And yet she did nothing. She had dozens—hundreds—of chances to make a move in Hubei Province.

The question had stayed with me ever since I learned who she was.

Why had she left me alive?

Was I not worth killing? Was it all just a game to her?

I didn't know the full story, but I was certain neither answer was right. I was Fire King Jeok Cheongang's only Disciple and a successor of the Fire Gate Clan.

If she got me into her hands, she could lure in Jeok Cheongang, who would become a major obstacle to Dark Heaven's future movements, and kill him. Even if that attempt came to nothing, she could still obtain the Fire Gate Clan's supreme arts.

There were plenty of ways to make a man talk.

Torture. Torture. And endless torture.

But she hadn't killed me when I was completely taken in by her. She hadn't abducted me either.

She had merely watched me right before my eyes, then vanished without a trace. Like an observer sent on someone else's orders.

My dry lips parted.

“Why is the Lord of Heaven so interested in me? Why go this far when there are people far more worth his attention?”

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress’s lips had pressed shut at some point. My question did nothing to open them.

After a brief silence, she gave only a short answer.

“What could an insignificant creature like you know of that omnipotent, exalted one’s will?”

Insignificant.

I studied her tense face, the way her gaze had dropped and how she pressed her teeth lightly against her lip.

A thought flashed through my mind. I spoke it aloud.

“You don’t know, do you?”

“…!”

I saw her eyes waver. A derisive laugh slipped out of me.

“Fucking idiot.”

“…What?”

“I said you’re a fucking idiot. You worthless fucking idiot of an old hag.”

That was enough to light the Southern Heaven Demon Emress’s fuse.

Rooooar!

A storm of qi swept out in every direction. Layer upon layer of pitch-black darkness wrapped around her.

Beside me, the guardian spirit steadied its ragged breathing and sent me a thought.

—If you were going to provoke her, couldn’t you have stalled a little longer?

I regretted it a little myself. But there was no other way.

We had to finish this before the humans and beasts still in the Inner Palace completed their mutation. Which of us fell and which remained standing came after that.

I sent a Sound Transmission to the guardian spirit. It was still grumbling, though it was hardly in fighting shape itself.

—Are you really a guardian spirit? Stop acting like you’re about to keel over and fight with everything you’ve got.

—How dare you insult me. Three hundred years ago, I would never have endured such humiliation from a mere human.

—Sure. That crazy bitch wouldn’t have been born yet, either.

—…Damn it.

Cursing in a manner hardly befitting a guardian spirit, it bristled from head to tail. Its gaze flicked over the two figures approaching us from front and back.

—This has become more difficult.

—Wow. I had absolutely no idea. Good thing you're a guardian spirit. Thanks for telling me.

—We'll take one each. The human male or the human female. Choose.

—Then I'll take the male.

—…

Does this bastard have no conscience?

That seemed to be what its pale blue eyes were asking me. Even in this godforsaken mess, I let out a short laugh and started walking.

Toward the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Step.

Maybe it was nerves, but my footstep sounded unusually loud. Her eyes had turned blood red, and a chill ran through me.

"You mean to fight me? You?"

Her voice was cold and eerie. I let out a deep sigh before answering.

"That hurts. We insignificant creatures ought to look out for each other. Don't you think?"

"…!"

"Choose. Kill me and get your ass kicked by the Lord of Heaven, or die nicely right here."

Hack—ptoo.

I spat out a mouthful of phlegm mixed with stale blood and raised my spearhead.

When I spoke again, my voice sounded unfamiliar. Cold.

"For the record… I'll fight until I die."

Fwoosh—boom!

Flamefire Path.

A single line of flame shot forward, consuming the air in its path.

And at the end of that path stood a monster wrapped in deep darkness.

Whoooosh—boom!

Bang!

An immense shockwave shook the world.

The ground split beneath Jin Taekyung's descending spearhead, and searing heat burst from the fissure.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress dodged the strike by a hair and thrust out her hand.

Kraaaaaash!

A palm strike carrying unprecedented qi collided with the spearhead slicing through space like a ray of light.

Qi collided with qi. The difference in strength was unmistakable.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded, and one figure was hurled backward.

Delight shone in the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's eyes.

That wretch is nothing.

Jin Taekyung's martial power had clearly advanced at an unbelievable pace. He had changed so much that she found herself wondering whether he was truly the same boy she had met in Hubei.

Perhaps the greatest obstacle to their grand plan was no longer the Beast Miao King, but Jin Taekyung.

But…

I've grown stronger still.

She could feel power unlike anything she had known boiling through her body.

The denser the demonic qi flowing from the rift grew, the stronger she became.

Even now.

Pop!

One step.

She vanished like a ghost and reappeared in midair.

As she plunged toward him like a meteor, Jin Taekyung opened his eyes wide. He was still buried deep in the ground.

Crunch.

Solid earth crumbled like mud beneath her strike. Jin Taekyung escaped it by a hair and flicked his sleeve.

A dagger flew at her from somewhere, as though he had conjured it from thin air. She avoided it easily and thrust out her hand with lightning speed.

Slash!

Her fingers only grazed him.

But curled like hooks, they tore through his martial uniform and cut into his thigh.

Blood spurted. Jin Taekyung staggered.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress beamed as she brought the edge of her hand down toward him.

Shu-whaack!

Chapter 702

Shwaaak!

A straightened hand-blade sliced through the air and came crashing down.

Slender and snow-white, it looked as though it had never been dipped in water. But Jin Taekyung knew how much blood had flowed from that hand. He knew what darkness lurked behind the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's dazzling smile.

Monster.

Those two words surfaced in his mind once more.

As the blood-red Force fell like a meteor toward the crown of his head, his legs, frozen as though nailed to the ground, moved at last.

Shhk!

The earth split like tofu. Jin Taekyung slipped past the Force by a hair and drove his spear forward like lightning.

Shwaaak!

The spearhead flew toward a single point with terrifying speed, power, and precision. Even a fistfighter who had spent a lifetime honing his techniques and reached the Supreme Peak realm would not have dared meet that strike head-on.

But the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was different.

No. Today, at least, she had the power to do exactly that.

Krrrkkk!

Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade.

She caught the spearhead between her palms as though bringing her hands together in prayer. Hellfire flickered around the blade as it trembled between them. Enough power was concentrated in those snow-white hands to keep them from being reduced to ash.

The corners of her unlined mouth lifted.

"With only this much…"

The instant her voice, filled with mockery, emerged—

Plop. Plip.

Drops of blood fell. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress noticed them and fell silent.

The pain reached her half a beat later. Jin Taekyung gave her a sheepish smile.

"Oh, I forgot to mention. This is Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron."

"…!"

"What were you saying?"

Her delicate brow furrowed. Jin Taekyung let go of the spear shaft and thrust out both arms.

Palm Force?

She was wrong.

Shhk! Shhk!

Two daggers shot toward her throat and chest. They were already too close to dodge, so she released the spearhead and snapped her sleeves.

Whoooosh!

Wind burst from the billowing fabric and sent the daggers flying. At that instant, Jin Taekyung's foot caught the end of White Flame's slowly tilting shaft.

No—he kicked it.

…What?

He kicked it? The divine weapon that would have helped him most in this fight?

A flash of light hurtled toward her face.

Shwaaack! Slash!

It happened in an instant. The attack was so unexpected that avoiding it completely was all but impossible. She turned her head on instinct, felt pain flare in her earlobe, and stared.

"How dare you!"

If it had only been her earring, she would not have been so furious. She had liked it, but she could always find another.

Her earlobe had been torn. Worse, her hair had been cut. Half of the thick, glossy hair she had always taken such pride in was gone.

"Die!"

Kraaaaaash!

The unprecedented energy that had faltered for a moment surged through her slender body. The pressure seemed capable of crushing a massive boulder in an instant.

But the Southern Heaven Demon Empress did not know that the young—almost absurdly young—enemy before her had once climbed a cliff with iron balls weighing well over a thousand *geun*[2995] strapped to his body.

Crack. Crrrunch!

The earth sank beneath the pressure crushing everything within a radius of over ten *jang*[2996], while the limbs of the humans and beasts struggling in the area twisted and snapped.

—Krrk, krrrk!

"Aaaaaagh!"

[2995] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand *geun* is 600 kg (about 1,300 lb).

[2996] A *jang* is ten Korean *ja*, or 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten *jang* is 30.3 m (about 99 ft).

Amid the blood and dying screams, Jin Taekyung endured the pressure and stamped his foot.

Boom!

A line of flame rose from his toe as he shot forward. At the same time, a spear he had somehow taken hold of swept fiercely from his fingertips and split the air like lightning.

Shwaaaargh! Boom!

The impact sent out a shockwave that shook the world. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress had caught the side of the spearhead with perfect precision. Power surged through her hand.

Crack!

The Scorching Yang Qi surrounding the spearhead, along with the steel that a skilled blacksmith had folded and tempered more than a hundred times, crumbled like tofu.

A smile full of killing intent touched her lips.

Foolish boy.

Jin Taekyung had made the mistake of giving up his peerless divine weapon of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. Now she would make him pay for wounding her beautiful body—and for cutting her precious hair.

I meant to bring him back as unharmed as possible. That won't do anymore.

At first, after hearing that the exalted Lord of Heaven had taken an interest in Jin Taekyung, she had intended to act as the Lord's faithful servant and capture the young man to offer him up.

Now she had changed her mind.

He was no longer a feisty cat in her eyes, but a proud beast. Young though he was, he had teeth and claws as sharp as a great tiger's. If she was careless, he might leave even worse wounds on her beautiful body.

Jin Taekyung rushed toward her, reflected in her blood-red eyes.

You should be prepared to lose a limb or two. I'll reattach them later anyway.

She snapped both sleeves.

Papapapap!

The shattered spearhead broke into dozens, then hundreds, of fragments that filled the air. Each one carried Force. Jin Taekyung drove his clenched fist into the wave of hidden weapons without hesitation.

Kraaaaaash!

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

A fire dragon burst from his callused fist and swallowed the fragments. Heated red-hot, they melted into liquid iron and spattered across the ground.

Hisssssssss.

But beneath the molten iron raining down like a shower, what awaited Jin Taekyung as he shot through the air was the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's slender, jade-like hand.

Whoosh!

Five fingers came at him, sweeping the air aside. They hooked like a rake toward his right arm.

Jin Taekyung twisted as though he had expected it all along.

He was not trying to save the arm she would otherwise tear away. He was putting his own neck in her path.

But at the same time, it was also a lethal move that struck at an opening the opponent had never expected.

This lunatic…!

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress screamed inwardly.

The Lord of Heaven had taken an interest in Jin Taekyung. He absolutely could not die. She had wanted to take him alive as a show of loyalty; the Lord had not even given her a specific order. If Jin Taekyung died by her hand, she might have to face the Lord's fury alone.

No!

She hurriedly dragged back her surging internal energy. The muscles and flow of qi-blood throughout her body, already committed to the strike, twisted against the sudden reversal. A wave of backflow swept through her.

Urk!

"Kwaaaagh!"

Blood shot up from deep within her and sprayed between her lips. At the last moment, she managed to turn her hand. The Force at her fingertips missed Jin Taekyung's throat.

Shhk! Spit!

The blade-sharp wind sliced his skin.

Jin Taekyung did not waver. He had never had any reason to.

This is the moment I've been waiting for.

His mind had gone cold. He had already made his calculations.

By his reckoning, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was at least on the level of the Ten Kings. She might even rival the Three Saints. Her martial arts could be no better than the Western Heaven Demon Lord's—perhaps worse—but her overwhelming internal energy more than made up for any gap.

And when facing a master of this level, there was only one possible method.

One opening.

He had wagered his life to create it. He would not get another chance.

And now…

I'll wager my life again.

Inventory Open. Summon.

Along with the commands ringing through his mind, he thrust out his hand like a flash of lightning.

Shhk!

A slender wrist, impossible to believe belonged to such a powerful monster, was cleanly severed.

"Aaaaaaaagh!"

Her scream was louder and more agonized than any Jin Taekyung had heard from the creatures of the Nanman Beast Palace writhing under the demonic qi. No, it was the worst scream he had ever heard.

In a way, that was only natural. People were born to forget, and the powerful, accustomed to causing pain, tended to forget their own.

Even so, she was the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

"Jin Taekyung—!"

Shhk!

She lunged with a shriek that seemed to tear through the air. Jin Taekyung met her blood-red gaze, now clouded with darkness, and knew instinctively that this time he could neither dodge nor block her attack completely.

The immense Internal Injury had thrown off her stance. The internal energy she had forced up while vomiting blood was wildly unstable. That made her all the more dangerous.

No. The real danger was the killing intent pouring from her.

"How dare you! How dare someone like you!"

His luck had only worked once.

Consumed by pain and fury, forgetting even her loyalty to her master, the monster thrust out a palm packed with power.

The world slowed. Darkness and blood-red Force churned together in the palm strike as it rushed toward him, erasing the space in its path.

Kraaaaaash!

The force was overwhelming, as though the sea and a great mountain had risen to engulf him.

Fear that made every hair on his body stand on end seized Jin Taekyung.

But he knew that if he took even one step back, everything would be over.

He had to go forward, even if it cost him his life.

Come.

He did not know what he was calling to. His foot came down on the blood-soaked earth.

Crush.

The ground sank beneath a step weighted with internal energy as heavy as his life, then burst with heat.

Boom!

Crouched low enough to skim the ground, he shot forward like a cannonball. A snow-white palm filled his vision, carrying power no human should have possessed. Beyond the blood-red flash was a face twisted like a fiend's.

"Die!"

At that instant—

Inventory Open. Summon.

Jin Taekyung's hand, spread wide as though ready to unleash a palm strike, closed. A cold spear shaft filled his empty palm, and its spearhead erased the distance between them.

Shwaaaargh! Shhk!

The spearhead tore past the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's neck by a hair. Faint delight lit her eyes.

I read him. Perfectly.

His technique was astonishing, and dangerous. But amid the chaos of the fight, she had predicted it.

Or so she believed—until, just as she was about to take off his head, a cold draft touched her back.

Shhk.

"…!"

A faint hiss reached her ear. She spun on instinct, but something icy and razor-sharp raked across her side.

Shhk!

Blood burst out like a fountain. She felt muscle and veins sever, her qi-blood tangling inside her.

Th-this is…

Backflow.

A second backflow had struck before she could even settle the Internal Injury she had suffered earlier—and it was more fatal than any wound she had received until now.

This was what he was after… from the start.

The realization flashed through her whitening vision. She swallowed the blood rising in her throat and turned.

At last, she saw it.

Goooooong.

Blue-white flames whirled at the tip of a transparent spearhead that had answered its master's call.

Beneath Jin Taekyung's deeply shadowed eyes, his lips moved silently, forming two words.

One Annihilation.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress's eyes flew wide.

—Human!

An urgent thought suddenly rang out. With it, a vast vortex unlike anything anyone in Nanman had ever seen erupted.

Kraaaaaash!

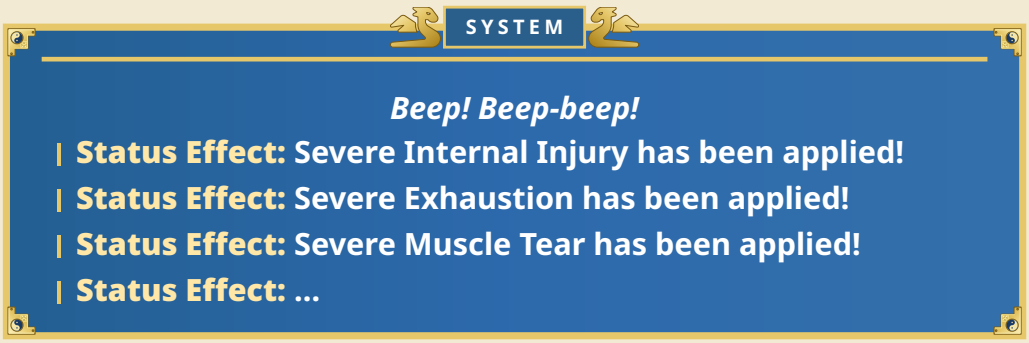
Chapter 703

Kwooooooong…!

I couldn’t breathe.

The roar still hadn’t faded. Its endless reverberations sounded impossibly distant.

And yet the System notifications rang clearly in my ears.



The notifications—or rather, the warning sounds—kept coming, itemizing just how bad my condition was.

If the System were a doctor, it would probably look at me with a grave expression and say:

Patient, I hate to tell you this, but… you’re really fucked this time. Why the hell do you keep using One Annihilation? Is dying young on your bucket list?

How considerate.

Just imagining it should have made me feel like shit. Strangely, it didn’t change my mood much. The reason was simple: reality was even shittier than anything I could imagine.

“Cough.”

Splatter. Drip, drip.

Blood burst from my mouth and scattered across the ground. I’d felt a few chunks in it, too. Pieces of my organs, no doubt. One Annihilation really gave you your money’s worth—

Fuck. It’s not a convenience-store lunchbox.

Damn it.

My vision blurred. Senses that had been sharp enough to rival a divine weapon moments ago were now as dull as an ax abandoned in a ruined cabin. White Flame, which I’d always swung around like a pinwheel, had become the heaviest thing in the world.

But one thing still worked well enough: I could feel the pain in my forearm.

Crunch. Crunch.

I stared at *it* through my blurred vision.

It kept chewing my flesh with teeth that jutted out like an animal's, swallowing the blood. Its eyes held nothing but greed and madness.

It was hard to believe it had once been human, like me.

"Good?"

Crunch.

"Yeah. Guess it is."

I didn't know why I was talking to it when I knew it couldn't understand me anymore. Or why I was letting the bastard livestream an eating show with my wrist.

Maybe I selfishly wanted someone else to do what had to be done. Or maybe I still felt a last shred of pity for something that had once been human.

Shwaaak! Slash!

Crunch…

Something sliced through the air, and the teeth that had been chewing so fiercely went slack.

I was staring at the young man, frozen with his red eyes wide, when a silver mane caked in blood and dust swept across my vision.

—Human. You don't look all right.

The guardian spirit. The moment I recognized it, my legs gave out. I caught hold of its mane and answered weakly.

"Don't people usually ask if someone's all right first?"

—I'm not human. You clearly weren't all right, so there was no need to ask.

"I like that about you. What about that pitch-black bastard?"

—I killed him. For the fourth time.

"What?"

—He kept getting back up. Each time, he recovered faster and grew stronger. This time may be no different.

The rift. More precisely, the demonic qi flowing from it.

And as the Masked Man grew stronger under its influence, the guardian spirit must have been growing weaker. Just like the sacred stone in its mouth, which could no longer give off the great radiance it had before.

The guardian spirit shares its power with the sacred stone.

Only now did I notice the deep wounds all over its body, its heaving shoulders and ragged breaths.

It must have caught me looking. It turned its massive body to hide the wounds.

"I'm sorry."

The guardian spirit studied me with its blue-white eyes, then shook its head.

—You did all you could.

"At the end…"

—I know. If those things hadn’t interfered, you would have succeeded.

I looked around weakly. Torn corpses lay everywhere.

They were the mutants that had finished transforming first and rushed me at the guardian spirit’s warning, just as I was about to unleash One Annihilation.

I didn’t see them coming.

No. I hadn’t had the chance to watch for them. I’d been too hard-pressed even to look around, and the mutants had charged straight at me.

And died.

What awaited roughly one hundred of them was the immense vortex created by One Annihilation.

But in that brief instant, split into smaller and smaller fractions of time, the mutants had instinctively stopped me and fulfilled their mission.

They’d bitten my forearm and turned my attack aside, blocked my view, and thrown themselves in front of a force they couldn’t stop.

And that was how one person survived.

“Southern Heaven Demon Empress.”

My voice came out almost as a groan. A figure standing amid the hazy dust took a step forward.

Scuff.

Everything in that section of the palace had been erased by the aftermath of One Annihilation. From its very center emerged the only monster to survive, her red eyes glowing.

Red. Everything was red.

The sky. The ground. Everything between them.

At the same time, things that should never have been visible came into view.

Ah.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress stared blankly at her hand.

The smooth, snow-white hand she had gained by taking several jiazi[2997] worth of internal energy and countless measures of vital essence was gone. In its place was a hand covered in fine wrinkles and age spots, as dry and thin as the branch of a dying tree.

“Ah. Aah…”

Tears welled in her eyes, red with burst blood vessels.

This couldn’t be happening. It couldn’t.

[2997] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar.

She had been more beautiful than anyone in the world. She was supposed to be beautiful.

But the great art she had cultivated for nearly a century had been broken, and her old, ugly appearance had returned like a curse.

Trembling with shock and rage, she realized that the aging she had kept at bay was not the only curse to come upon her.

It hurts.

Only when sudden agony made her look down at herself did she understand.

Flesh had been torn from her side as though an invisible beast had bitten it away. One arm was gone entirely. And half her face had melted in the tremendous heat.

"…!"

Her eyes flew wide. It was impossible. It should never have happened.

The wound in her side could heal. A skilled enough practitioner could even reattach her arm without leaving a scar.

But not her face. Unless she followed the same path as the Blood Lord she so despised, those terrible burns would leave their mark.

"No. This… this can't…"

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress stopped short. Someone had appeared in her blood-red eyes, now wet with tears.

Jin Taekyung.

She could see him. And feel him.

After the dazzling flash that had erased everything, he was left with no strength, little more than an empty shell. That insignificant creature had stolen her youth and beauty.

A single thought seized her.

Kill him.

At that moment, her mind, muddled by countless emotions, turned cold.

The monster who had lived for an age wrapped herself in darkness and moved forward without hesitation.

Scuff. Scuff.

Crack.

With every step, the energy pouring from her body crushed everything around her.

She had lost her youth, but she still had the strength to kill him. The bleeding from her side and arm had stopped, and her battered insides were slowly settling.

If the sudden return of age was a curse, then the demonic qi pouring from the rift, growing denser by the moment, was a blessing.

It would let her tear apart Jin Taekyung, who could barely stand, and the reeking old beast in front of him.

—Stop.

Ssssss.

Light spread from the guardian spirit as its thought rang out. The thousand mutants packed around it crouched low, but the Southern Heaven Demon Empress kept walking.

Bang!

A palm strike shot forward without the slightest hesitation. Darkness mixed with blood-red Force pressed down on the sacred stone's light and engulfed Jin Taekyung.

Boom!

The ground burst apart with a deafening crash. In that instant, the guardian spirit bit Jin Taekyung by the nape and darted away like lightning, releasing a low growl.

—The sacred stone…

It left the thought unfinished, but the truth was cruelly clear.

Rumble…

A faint trembling came from inside its mouth. Like an old man facing a young man in his prime, the sacred stone was losing strength even now.

So was the White Tiger that had guarded it for so many years.

Even the spiritual energy left by the imugi wasn't enough?

The guardian spirit hadn't expected that energy to restore all its former strength. The Water God Dragon's earlier mutation had left it with little energy to give.

The demonic qi is too strong. Strong enough to suppress even the sacred stone's power.

The demonic qi had already spread beyond the Inner Palace and was encroaching on the Outer Palace.

The guardian spirit had brought the beasts of the Sacred Land with it. But if they, too, fell under the demonic qi's influence while the sacred stone weakened, the situation would spiral out of control.

No. It was already as bad as it could get.

Nearly a thousand mutants, wholly under the demonic qi's influence, surrounded them without leaving a gap. And the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had survived to come after them.

At this rate…

The guardian spirit's expression darkened. Then Jin Taekyung spoke, his voice weak.

"Go."

—What?

"You've worked hard. You've been through enough."

—…!

Jin Taekyung met its wide blue-white eyes and struggled to his feet, using White Flame as a cane.

“That’s enough. Get out and save the people. Get them as far away from this goddamn place as you can, as fast as you can.”

—How can you say that now…?

“I guarantee it. No matter how fast you are, I won’t last long if you take me with you. I’ll probably start whining for you to put me down in less than half a shichen[2998]. I’ll die if I don’t circulate my qi.”

The words were playful, but the judgment behind them wasn’t. The guardian spirit fell silent.

Jin Taekyung grinned.

“So go. Before it’s too late.”

He turned to face the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. His eyes looked ready to go dark at any moment; hers burned blood-red with fury.

“All right. I’ll come quietly, so let’s stop this. Lord of Heaven or some dogshit lord, let’s go see him.”

Instead of answering, she raised her hand.

Swish, spit!

Finger Qi shot toward him like a beam of light and tore the back of his neck. Jin Taekyung shrugged as if it were nothing.

“If you’re angry, just say so. I’ve lost enough blood already. What if I die on the way?”

“That would be troublesome,” she said coldly.

“Now we’re finally talking—”

“You mustn’t die that easily. I’m going to tear you apart slowly with my own hands.”

“…I guess we’re not exactly communicating. What are you planning to do about the fallout?”

“It’ll be fine. The Lord of Heaven will be pleased if I bring him the divine artifact. The White Tiger’s pelt will be a bonus.”

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled brightly and opened her hand.

Kwoooong—!

A tremendous rumble swept across the Nanman Beast Palace.

[2998] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Chapter 704

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress was certain.

Give her the time it took to drink a cup of tea, and she could end this tiresome battle. That was all the time the brat she wanted to tear apart and his beast had left to live.

But as she raised her hand to strike, that certainty cracked.

Kwoooong—!

A vast rumble rose from somewhere. At the same time, the air rippled and the wind stopped. Sensing the powerful wave of qi coming from beyond the thick darkness, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress clenched her teeth.

This is…!

A master. One strong enough to resist the demonic qi's influence.

The thought and her response came in the same instant. Realizing something had gone wrong, she released the internal energy gathered in her remaining hand and shouted—not toward the approaching master, but toward the person she had to kill before it was too late.

"Kill him!"

Kwooooooosh!

A vast palm force tinged with murky light tore through the air. It was not the only thing hurtling toward Jin Taekyung.

Nearly a thousand humans and beasts—mutants made more vicious and powerful by the demonic qi—lunged together with a chorus of shrieks.

Pap-pap. Shhhhhk!

—Krrk, kraaaah!

Teeth harder and sharper than steel glinted in the darkness. The mutants charged with strength and speed far beyond what their bodies had once possessed, while the palm force streaked above their heads like a meteor.

All of it bore down on the two figures standing in the dark beneath a faint glow.

No. It was meant to tear apart the one human who had dealt the Southern Heaven Demon Empress an insult she could never wash away.

Jin Taekyung watched it come. The corner of his weary mouth twisted.

"Too bad. You're already too late."

"…!"

Only a shichen[2999] ago, those words had come from her lips. Now they came back to her, thick with mockery.

Boom! Fwoosh!

[2999] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

The darkness on either side burst apart as though the demonic qi itself had exploded. Green Force, the color of forest and leaves, surged through the opening and smashed everything in its path.

No—it tore into them and devoured them.

Like a wild beast.

Krrrunch!

The earth shook. Compressed air burst outward, sweeping away the wind laced with bitter demonic qi. The green Force ripped the limbs from the mutants rushing in on every side, then opened its jaws toward the immense palm force.

Kwaaang! Rumble!

Light mingled where the attacks collided. After a deafening roar that made it seem as though the sky itself had split apart, a terrifying shock wave shook the surrounding space.

Beyond it, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress stared wide-eyed at her palm force as it faded away helplessly.

They canceled each other out?

Who was she?

One of the Lord of Heaven's most loyal servants. A master he trusted enough to place Southern Heaven in her hands. In her own eyes, she was among the greatest and most exalted beings beneath heaven and earth.

Jin Taekyung had cost her a considerable amount of strength, but she could still tear an ordinary Supreme Peak master apart in moments.

And yet their attacks had canceled each other out.

She did not want to believe it. But she was not stupid enough to deny what had happened before her eyes, nor did it take long to guess who had arrived.

It has to be him.

Fist Force of that magnitude. The massive figure taking shape through the settling dust.

Her voice came out cold.

"…Yayul Cheok. The Beast Miao King."

Boom!

She swept her sleeve aside. The wind from it cleared the dust, revealing a giant of a man whose half-gray beard hung like an old tiger's mane.

Behind his towering frame, a young man leaned against the massive body of the White Tiger.

"You're late. Very late."

Jin Taekyung's voice was faint. The Beast Miao King answered calmly.

"I'm sorry. I came too late."

"I almost died out here."

“That won’t happen.”

He thrust out a hand as fast as lightning.

Bang.

The sound was like a drum bursting. Jin Taekyung’s body jerked, and the guardian spirit hurriedly caught him as he started to collapse. It bared its teeth on instinct, but Jin shook his head and opened his mouth.

“Urk. Ueeecch!”

Shwaaaaaak!

Dark red blood poured from him, soaking the guardian spirit’s broad back. Feeling the hot, dead blood run through its fur like vomit, it muttered.

“What a wonderful feeling.”

“…!”

“Don’t look at me like that, large human. I am—”

The guardian spirit was about to continue addressing the wide-eyed Beast Miao King when Jin Taekyung pushed himself upright. Having spat out the dead blood, he sounded much more alive.

“Not exactly the best time for introductions, but say hello. This is Whitey. I just adopted him.”

“Adopted? How dare you!”

“Oh. So Whitey’s fine?”

“You bastard!”

Jin grinned as the guardian spirit bristled, forgetting the danger around them. Then the Beast Miao King suddenly swept both hands outward.

Boom!

Green Fist Force struck a murky palm force in midair. At the same instant, the transparent spearhead that had hung limp moved.

Slash!

A dozen or so mutants trying to exploit the opening were cut apart before they could scream.

Another group rushed at Jin’s back as he briefly staggered. They saw the enormous forepaw waiting for them.

Whoosh! Crunch!

Blood spurted like a fountain. Severed limbs tumbled across the ground.

The guardian spirit let out a low growl. Jin stood back-to-back with it, raised White Flame, and pointed its spearhead in one direction.

“And the fucking bitch who interrupted while someone else was talking… You know her, right?”

The Beast Miao King nodded. An ugly old woman was reflected in his dark eyes.

“Yes. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress.”

His voice seemed to boil with anger that could not be hidden.

Countless mutants still surrounded them. The demonic qi had taken their original forms from them, but they were the tribespeople of this land—the people he had cherished more than anyone.

No. *Had* cherished was wrong. He still did.

The ache that had started in his chest the moment he saw them was proof enough.

I hoped I wouldn't be too late.

He had run until he could hardly breathe, wringing every last measure of strength from himself to get here. Then he had seen the Nanman Beast Palace in the distance, engulfed in darkness and flame, and known.

He was already too late.

To reach this place, he had passed more than mountains and plains, rivers and valleys.

He had seen a hellscape.

It brought back fragments of the Great Faction War, that horror from decades ago, and cut his heart to pieces. The bodies of tribespeople who had failed to escape lay crushed beneath fallen buildings. Streets that had rung with music and laughter not long ago belonged to surging darkness and fire.

And now the one most responsible for that hellscape stood before him.

"I swear this as the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace."

Fire blazed in his reddened eyes. There was no trace of the man who loved a drink and good company, who laughed heartily when he had had his fill.

Decades ago, he had led ten thousand warriors north against the Demonic Cult's Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples and earned his place among the Ten Kings. Now that giant spoke in a voice cold as steel.

"I will tear your limbs apart piece by piece."

Jin poked his head out from behind the Beast Miao King's broad back.

"Thought I'd save you some trouble. I've already cut off one of her arms."

He was still pale, but color was returning to his face. The hand around his spear no longer trembled. He drew a deep breath and stepped forward.

Scuff.

Just one step.

The mutants crowding every side flinched, but none dared charge. Their reason had been paralyzed, yet the mutation had sharpened their instincts. They sensed the change in the air.

They sensed, too, that the master who should have ordered them forward had fallen silent.

Their instincts were right. For the second time since coming to Nanman, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress felt threatened.

This isn't good…

Ordinarily, she would have snorted at the thought. The Beast Miao King might be one of the Ten Kings, but he could not have closed the gap between them.

Now things were different.

Jin Taekyung's One Strike had been powerful enough to freeze her with fear for an instant. It had cost her an arm and much of her strength. With her in this condition, the Beast Miao King was a threat.

Jin had recovered a little strength with his help, and the guardian spirit still held considerable qi. The mutants were no match for either of them.

But they were not the only reason her unease kept growing.

Why? Why haven't they appeared?

Like the Western Heaven Demon Lord, who had died in Sichuan a few months ago, she commanded a sizable force: roughly five hundred subordinates. Perhaps not enough to be called an army, but they were handpicked fighters, hidden from Nanman's people and held ready for precisely such a situation.

Yet—

They still haven't come.

More than half a shichen[3000] had passed since the rift opened. Only the Masked Man had appeared on time.

By now, over half her force should have crossed through the Moving Formation engraved on the mirror she had given Baeksang. The rest should have sealed the Outer Palace gates from outside.

Even if something went wrong with the Moving Formation, they should have shown up somehow by now.

She pressed her lips together. Then the ground beneath her feet began to tremble.

Creak. Creak-creak.

A faint smile touched her face. Her subordinates had finally arrived.

She had selected every one of those five hundred fighters herself. They practiced demonic martial arts, and the demonic qi would make them stronger still. No matter how many beasts remained in the Outer Palace, they could not block their way.

"Tear my limbs off? You?"

She let out a short laugh. Seeing Jin Taekyung's and the Beast Miao King's faces stiffen, she could not help laughing again.

"I'll admit it. You fought better than I expected. No—no one could have imagined it would come to this."

She kept the rest to herself.

[3000] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

But now it's over.

As though nothing had happened, she began to walk lightly forward. The taut air seemed to ease. Then the Beast Miao King spoke.

"Someone did."

"What?"

"Someone foresaw this. He walked a path he couldn't turn back from and tormented himself with guilt, but he never gave up hope. Not until the very end."

She blinked, unable to make sense of it.

The Beast Miao King spun like lightning and drove out a fist.

Kwooooooosh!

Green Force punched through the darkness, carving a path.

Along it came the reinforcements who would decide the battle's outcome.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

A company clad in white garments and armor emerged. The man at their head bowed to the Beast Miao King.

"Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit… pays his respects to the Palace Lord."

Chapter 705

"Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit, pays his respects to the Palace Lord."

The moment the Southern Heaven Demon Empress heard those words, she thought the world had stopped.

Time slowed. Everything around her surged forward like a wave and filled her vision.

Clothing and armor as white as snow, instead of the pitch-black martial uniforms that were practically Dark Heaven's symbol.

Three hundred warriors whose dress and features marked them unmistakably as Bai people. Beasts beside them, growling low.

And then…

Flap.

A flag stirred in a breeze from somewhere. Three characters had been scrawled across it in a bold, soaring hand.

Baekcheon Unit.

…!

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress's pupils trembled.

She couldn't understand why those characters beneath the endless dark sky unsettled her so deeply. Why a piece of old silk, yellowed by the years and fluttering in the wind, should make her uneasy at all.

Or why a memory she had once dismissed was returning now.

Demon Empress. Baeksang is secretly training warriors and beasts. They're all Bai people, and after a thorough investigation, we found that most of them…

Are orphans who lost their parents in the Great Faction War or the plague. They disappeared after the great fire several years ago.

Y-you knew?

For a long time. He's set up a refuge somewhere called Wenshan, hasn't he?

Th-then, may this lowly servant dare ask the Demon Empress just one thing?

You want to know why I'm watching when I know what he's doing.

Forgive my impertinence, but yes. Even now, a considerable portion of the vast supplies flowing to Baeksang is being used to train warriors. If he should ever harbor different intentions…

So what? It's amusing.

Pardon?

Think about it. What could possibly change just because he feeds elixirs to orphans who have nowhere to go and teaches them a few forms of martial arts?

Th-that…

Scrap iron is scrap iron, however many times you hammer it. You'll never make a divine weapon that way. But I rather enjoy watching Baeksang struggle over his scrap iron, dreaming of what it might become. And imagining the look on his face when hope turns to despair.

…!

Besides, Baeksang will never turn against me. Even if he does, that will only give me something else to enjoy.

That conversation had taken place more than a dozen years ago.

The spy, who had become a Great Chieftain at a young age, had struck his forehead against the floor until it bled, then left. In time, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress forgot about him.

No—she erased him from her mind.

What happened in a remote mountain valley where no one set foot gradually ceased to interest her, too.

It was too insignificant to keep watching.

It was only natural. She held Baeksang's leash, and even if he cut it himself and charged at her, she possessed more than enough power to crush him to death in an instant.

Such arrogance, such ease, belonged only to those with overwhelming strength.

Only now did the Southern Heaven Demon Empress realize that Baeksang, the hunting dog she had believed incapable of betraying her, had torn off his leash.

Her own arrogance had brought them here.

"…Baekcheon. The Baekcheon Unit."

She spoke the words like a groan.

While she dreamed of the dark sky to come, someone else had looked toward a sky strewn with white clouds.

No. He had carried that sky in his heart.

Even as he followed another's orders like a hunting dog forced into a leash he had never wanted, he must have written those characters with guilt and anger at knowing his path was wrong and being unable to leave it.

On that yellowed, worn silk that had once been dazzlingly white, he must have drawn the sky he had wanted to see.

And the wish he could not fulfill with his own hands had been passed on to one person.

"Leave. I have already cleared the East Gate. The guards at the underground prison will be more lax than usual, so the Han Chinese should be able to escape this place without much difficulty."

…!

At the low voice echoing through the air, Jin Taekyung looked between the Baekcheon Unit and the Beast Miao King, his eyes wide. A groan escaped him.

"No way."

It was as though scattered pieces were slowly falling into place.

His eyes bloodshot and fixed on the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, the Beast Miao King continued reciting what someone had told him a few days earlier.

"Go straight to Wenshan, northeast of here. Show this to the people on its highest peak."

Whoosh. Clatter.

Something flew from the Beast Miao King's hand, arced through the air, and landed at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's feet.

It was half of a jade identification token. The only proof of authority that could move the Baekcheon Unit.

"I've gone down a path I can't turn back from. I can't stop of my own will, and even if I did, it wouldn't be enough to stop the grand scheme."

The Beast Miao King's voice trembled.

He could almost see his sworn brother's face in that dimly lit room. Baeksang had cut through his own wrist—a wrist as precious to a swordsman as his life.

And he could hear Baeksang's last words.

"I won't stop. So… you mustn't stop either, Palace Lord. Go all the way with that boy, Jin Taekyung. Take a different path from mine."

That was all. The sworn elder brother had left, and the sworn younger brother had remained.

Three days later, the Baekcheon Unit knelt before the token in the Beast Miao King's hand. They remembered the charge given to them by the man who had become their father and teacher after they lost their homes and families.

If someone other than me brings you this token one day… he is the lord you must serve.

And so the three hundred warriors who had lain hidden in a remote mountain valley for decades descended with the Beast Miao King.

Rumors of warriors racing across the wilderness spread quietly, but swiftly.

The Palace Lord has returned!

Our Dai people will join the Palace Lord! Protect this land from the traitors who colluded with Dark Heaven, usurped the Palace Lord's position, and betrayed Nanman!

Mobilize every warrior. Send out messengers, now!

As many as ten thousand warriors headed for the Nanman Beast Palace, leaving behind a vacuum of equal size.

The tribal chieftains who had rebelled against Baeksang and left the Nanman Beast Palace led their warriors to join their true Palace Lord.

You…

We'll follow you to the death, Palace Lord.

One day passed. Then another.

By then, they had become a vast army. They were racing toward the Nanman Beast Palace when they encountered an unexpected enemy.

Or so they thought.

The force numbered roughly three thousand. Then the Bai man at its head stepped forward alone and knelt.

We surrender.

The Beast Miao King asked why. The Bai man answered with a dazed look.

The being who guards the divine artifact opened our eyes—all of us. It showed us which path was right and which choice we had to make.

The Beast King Stone was a legend. A miracle.

And that day, the Bai man—no, the Captain of the Guards—was not the only one who witnessed the wondrous sight on Ailao Mountain.

That Han Chinese bastard… No. Great Hero Jin Taekyung told us to find you at once, Palace Lord. He said everything would be lost if we were any later.

Once the three thousand warriors who had surrounded Ailao Mountain joined them, nothing could stop them. Not rugged mountains, deep swamps, or jungles thick with undergrowth.

Nor could the group that had realized something was wrong and hurried toward the Nanman Beast Palace.

"I had to rush to the Inner Palace and didn't see it through to the end. How did the battle turn out?"

The Beast Miao King asked without taking his eyes off the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit, wiped blood from his cheek. The heat of battle still burned in his eyes.

"Two hundred casualties on our side."

"And theirs?"

"Annihilated. We killed or captured every last one."

Jin Taekyung, who had watched it all unfold, gave a short laugh. He didn't know every detail, but he had a good idea how things had gone.

"Old hag. You're fucked, huh?"

…!

Crunch.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress clenched her teeth before she could stop herself. The metallic tang of blood filled her mouth.

Dead. All of them.

Five hundred elite fighters, wiped out.

The thousands who had arrived with the Beast Miao King had crushed her last move—the one that could have turned this dangerous situation around in an instant.

No. This can't be happening…!

Fury boiled up inside her. Worse than the fury was the unease, the cold creeping through her chest.

The two characters filling the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's mind now were death.

…Die? I'm going to die? Me?

She couldn't believe it.

She had lived for more than a hundred and thirty years. Since her youth, she had stopped at nothing to become beautiful and stay young. She had cast aside every human scruple countless times, building formidable martial prowess along the way.

She had never imagined that, if her life ended, it would end at someone else's hands.

Now that absurd possibility was becoming real. Drawing closer before her eyes.

With killing intent as sharp as the point of an awl.

Thoom.

Hundreds of feet stepped forward at once, their combined impact spreading as a tremendous echo.

Grrrr.

The beasts carrying warriors on their backs growled low.

Light flowed from the largest White Tiger at their center, enveloping them all and shielding them from the darkness.

Fwoooosh.

Faint but unmistakable light. The mutants sensed the power of the sacred stone that had shared this land's fate for ages, and instinctively backed away.

Or perhaps they sensed something else, too.

They could not win against these people. Their bodies had grown fiercer and stronger, but it would make no difference. Not even if the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, who led them, joined the fight.

—Krrk.

—Kk.

Their cries sounded almost like groans. Nearly a thousand monsters stood there, as hideous as the sounds they made.

The Baekcheon Unit did not waver. They leveled weapons still wet with their previous enemies' blood at the mutants.

Shing.

Hundreds of spears and blades flashed in the dim light.

Decades ago, someone had called these warriors scrap iron and treated them as a diversion. She had been wrong.

No. Perhaps she had been right back then.

But the scrap iron had been hammered, cooled, and heated again and again until it became something new.

Hard steel. Then keen blades capable of cutting even steel.

And only one man in all the world could wield the blade called the Baekcheon Unit.

"Give the order, Palace Lord. No…"

A middle-aged man whose black hair had turned half gray with the passage of time—the Commander of the Baekcheon Unit, Wang Ho—spoke in a weighty voice.

"My lord."

His gaze turned, and every member of the Baekcheon Unit looked the same way.

The giant standing before them like an iron tower—the Beast Miao King, Yayul Cheok—opened his mouth.

"I'm going forward. Follow me."

"As you command."

That was all.

In the next instant, they moved as one. Like a wave rolling in from the open sea. Like an arrow loosed from its bow. Like a bolt of lightning.

At their head, an enormous White Tiger shot forward beside the Beast Miao King.

—Kraaaaaaang!

Krrrunch!

Its roar shook heaven and earth. Its forepaw swept through everything in its way, tearing and crushing.

Gripping the guardian spirit's mane, white enough to match his own pallor, Jin Taekyung muttered,

"No, fuck. I'm exhausted enough to die, so why am I—"

His dismay at the sudden acceleration—and his suspicion that the guardian spirit might be a Korean-made tiger—vanished the next moment.

To be precise, they had no choice but to vanish.

Gooooong.

The air froze. At the center of a whirlwind rising as it drew in the surrounding darkness, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress lifted her head.

Jin yanked the guardian spirit's mane backward at lightning speed.

His ace in the hole: reverse gear.
The guardian spirit understood his intention perfectly and launched itself.
Forward.
Whoosh!
—Hold on tight, human!
“…”
No, fuck.

Chapter 706

A thought occurred to me.

Can't I sit this one out now?

The greater good. A spirit of self-sacrifice. Laying down your life for others. All that stuff.

All good things. Heartwarming, if a little embarrassing to say out loud. But…

Haven't I done enough of that already?

I had come all the way to this cursed continent-sized greenbelt for the greater good, and I had fought while wearing my spirit of self-sacrifice over my entire body—so thoroughly that it might as well have been tattooed onto me.

Actually, considering how many battles I'd fought in Nanman, just saying I'd *fought* didn't do it justice.

I'd fought a fucking lot.

In forests. In fields. In swamps and jungles.

I'd driven my spear into spiders the size of houses. I'd answered the Nanman warriors who kept coming for glory with fire and fists.

If only it had ended there.

At the Poisonblood Grounds, I'd faced two Supreme Peak masters at once. Before I'd even recovered from that, I'd had to fight the monster known as the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

And then there was One Annihilation.

One Annihilation. Killing everything in a single strike—that was what the name meant. Lately, though, I'd begun to wonder if *everything* included me.

What the fuck was I pouring into that one blow? My internal energy or my lifespan?

Still, things had not turned out too badly. Just when I had been wondering whether that was the day I would see the ending of my life, the Beast Miao King and the Baekcheon Unit had appeared. With the Beast Miao King's help, I had partially recovered from my Internal Injury, and I had also learned that allies were already swarming outside the Inner Palace.

With the battle finally turning in our favor, I could breathe a little easier.

Until one insane tiger suddenly hit the gas.

Whoosh!

No, fuck. Did this bastard live on Frosted Flakes?[3001]

I'd noticed it when we first met on Ailao Mountain: the guardian spirit was faster than the three hundred warriors of the Baekcheon Unit. Faster even than the Beast Miao King.

[3001] Frosted Flakes is a breakfast cereal advertised with a tiger mascot.

Across the vast Inner Palace, now reduced to ruins, a thousand mutants stood in our way like an iron wall.

The guardian spirit's silver body shot toward the Southern Heaven Demon Empress beyond them. Its thought rang through my head.

—Hold on tight, human!

Is he trying to kill me…?

At that instant, a massive, murky light erupted above the mutants' heads.

Kraaaaaaash!

—Duck.

Along with the brief thought, the guardian spirit tilted its body. Its powerful forepaw struck the ground, and its enormous body changed direction at an angle.

Whoosh!

Those instincts, those movements—*spiritual creature* hardly covered it. *Divine beast* seemed closer.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress's palm strike, packed with tremendous internal energy, missed its target and slammed into the ground.

Boom! Rumble, rumble!

Dust billowed up. Countless fragments came hurtling through it toward us, and I brought White Flame's spearhead down.

Whoosh!

The spearhead whistled through the air. Debris flung up by the impact crumbled to powder and scattered.

Then—

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Hundreds of figures riding enormous beasts burst through the darkness and pale dust.

They charged in a triangular wedge, carrying tremendous weight and momentum. At its tip, a half-gray-haired middle-aged man drove out a fist.

The Beast Miao King.

Fwoom! Boom!

No furious shout. No command.

In place of his voice, green Fist Force erupted, crushing dozens of mutants in an instant and opening a gap. Three hundred charging spears drove into it like sharp awls.

Kra-crack!

Blood burst forth. Severed limbs flew high into the air.

One thousand against three hundred. Humans and beasts against monsters.

Slice! Slice!

Whoosh! Stab-stab-stab!

"Guh!"

—Kraaaaaaang!

Screams and the sounds of blades cutting flesh rang out on every side.

The Baekcheon Unit's charge crushed hundreds of mutants, but a fierce close-quarters battle awaited them. The Beast Miao King shot past it toward the true enemy waiting for him.

"Southern Heaven Demon Empress!"

His body surged forward like a streak of light alongside his roar. A moment later, the aftermath of their collision, carrying a distant flash of light, shook the foundations of the earth.

Boom! Rumble!

Figures and sharpened weapons clashed in a blur. Above them, the darkness slowly gave way before the green Force.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress is already exhausted. The Beast Miao King has the advantage.

But the close-quarters battle wasn't going nearly as well.

The beasts, made bigger and stronger by mutation, were a match for First Rate masters. The warriors had retained all the martial arts they'd known as humans, and now they moved faster than ever as they went after the Baekcheon Unit.

Like this one.

Whoosh! Slice!

A mutant's head flew up with a sharp cutting sound.

The Baekcheon warrior who had failed to notice it behind him stared at me, eyes wide.

"No matter how busy you are, you've got to watch your back."

"Thank you. But who are you…?"

The Beast Miao King or the Baekcheon Unit. After a moment's hesitation between the two, I answered.

"An ally. I'll take the lead. Follow me."

I didn't have much choice.

The Baekcheon Unit could stand against such overwhelming numbers because every single one of its members had reached at least the realm of a Supreme First Rate master. The mutants, whose bodies had been completely consumed by demonic qi, were powerful.

With the Beast Miao King gone from their midst, the guardian spirit and I had to lead the charge.

"…Shit. Now that I think about it, why am I—"

—Is it my imagination, or are you fighting just fine while you complain?

"Be honest. You've got a grudge against me, don't you?"

Crack!

Maybe demonic qi drove the mutant's ferocity. Maybe it was loyalty to the commander it wanted to protect. Either way, it charged out of the dust and filled my vision—until the guardian spirit crushed it in a single blow.

—A grudge?

"Don't play dumb, you bastard. You accelerated like your life depended on it because I set fire to Ailao Mountain."

Kra-crack!

A single sweep of its forepaw tore the heads off four or five mutants. The guardian spirit clicked its tongue—despite being a tiger.

—Ridiculous.

"Are you sure?"

—No.

"Then is this revenge for the Thousand-Year Spider that lived upstairs?"

—What nonsense is that?

"I've thought it over, and it's suspicious as hell. You know what they say. Our friendly neighborhood Thousand-Year Spider… up!"

Stab!

With that shout, I thrust White Flame straight through the head of a tiger that had leaped at us, casting a shadow over the guardian spirit.

Grrrk…

Its cry died away. With the dead tiger still impaled on my spear, I swung it hard.

Fwoom! Crack!

The carcass, weighing well over several hundred geun,[3002] flew into other mutants and crushed them.

"If you weren't holding a grudge, you wouldn't throw a patient who needs bed rest into a mess like this. That's my conclusion."

Whoosh! Slice!

I swept my spear sideways in one fluid motion. Five heads flew along its path.

The headless corpses collapsed at the same speed they had charged. The guardian spirit stared blankly at the sight and muttered,

—I think your idea of a patient differs from mine.

"Are you insane? Can't you see what shape I'm in?"

—I can. That is why I said it.

"You just don't understand. My bones ache when I breathe."

Stab!

[3002] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb).

—You seem perfectly capable of stabbing everything around you. That hardly makes a convincing argument.

"Damn it. I'm only doing this to stay alive…"

—Do you know something?

"What?"

—For a human, you are remarkably bad at lying.

"What's that supposed to—"

I didn't have time to finish.

Crack! Whoosh!

A silver mane wet with blood scattered through the air. The guardian spirit leaped upward after bursting a mutant's head, then swung its forepaw as it descended.

Its hooklike claws carried blade-sharp wind and an energy that could only be called Force.

Boom! Rumble!

One strike.

Amid the thunderous sound and the vibrations, dozens of mutants were sent flying as bloody pulp, and even more mutants rushed forward to fill the empty space.

Whoosh!

—Kweeeek!

Their movements were swift and fierce, at odds with their grotesque cries. Streams of Sword Energy poured from some of their weapons—proof they had once been renowned warriors even in Nanman.

But—

—Kraaaaaaang!

The guardian spirit existed solely to protect the sacred stone. At the roar of that enormous White Tiger, unlike any anyone had ever seen, the mutants froze.

As though we'd planned it, I brought White Flame down at an angle.

Cut them. All at once.

The three jiazi[3003] of Scorching Yang Qi were gone. So were the blue-white flames that had once burned around the transparent spearhead.

All I had left now was a body as heavy as waterlogged cotton, along with a small amount of internal energy—so little that I wondered whether it could fill even one handful—and the only divine weapon I could still trust: White Flame.

That was all. Yet I couldn't explain—

Slice!

Why I kept cutting without pause.

[3003] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar; three jiazi are 180 years.

Stab!

And stabbing.

Crack!

And swinging my spear at the mutants.

Why I forced my aching legs to hold on so I wouldn't fall from the guardian spirit's back.

No. Perhaps I dimly understood.

Even the meaning behind what the guardian spirit had said to me moments earlier.

"…Damn it."

The curse escaped me before I could stop it. The guardian spirit laughed softly.

—I told you. You are bad at lying.

"…"

—If staying alive were all you wanted, you would never have come here. Yet exhausted as you are, you will not stop fighting.

"Enough. Shut up."

—Why? Do you pity those who were human like you before they became monsters? Or do you want to kill the vile human who turned them into monsters?

"…"

Its thought whispered inside my head. My breath caught, and something hot rose in my chest.

But the hand I thrust forward was still driving my spear toward another mutant's throat.

Thrust!

The transparent spearhead cut through flesh and bone. Darkness slowly receded from eyes that had been black from edge to edge.

Death took its place.

Thud.

The body collapsed. I stared at the nameless warrior's grotesquely twisted face and murmured, "Did he feel pain?"

—Yes. Probably.

Crack!

The guardian spirit swung its massive forepaw, killing the mutant leopard that had charged at me and sending it flying like a cannonball, then continued, calm as ever.

—But after that brief pain, a great, warm rest would have been waiting for him. Simply being alive must be agony for them now.

"…"

—They do not resent you. So stop blaming yourself, human.

Damn it.

I knew. I'd done my best. I'd risked my life again and again to stop this disaster and come all the way here.

But doing my best didn't always bring the best result.

I should have stopped it.

In the end, I had failed to stop it. I had saved many people, but I had also failed to save many others.

Ultimately, the only thing I could do was end their lives with everything I had.

Just like now.

Fwooooooosh!

I swung with all my strength. The spearhead tore through the wind and split the air, and my whole body screamed from the toll One Annihilation had taken.

Pain so fierce my vision went white.

But I gritted my teeth and endured it. I sent a single spear packed with terrifying strength and speed toward the people who had once been human like me.

Kra-crack!

The spearhead carved an enormous arc. In its wake, a raging gale filled with dark red blood.

Severed heads and limbs rose into the air. Countless deaths followed. Countless moments of rest.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The first time I had wanted to cover my ears at the clear ringing of the chimes announcing EXP gained. The first time the sight of my enemies collapsing while spraying blood had felt so unbearably sorrowful.

But I didn't stop.

Slice. Slice. Slice!

I cut. Cut again. And kept cutting.

Until nothing stood in my way. Until my spearhead passed through empty air.

Fwoom!

The world tilted.

No—the body that could not withstand the force carried by the spearhead tilted.

As I began to roll off the guardian spirit's back, a rough hand caught me.

"It's over. Please stop."

Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit.

Shock rang in his voice. Breathing hard, I looked around.

The Baekcheon Unit had lost more than half its number. Countless bodies lay in pools of blood all around us.

But…

No.

He was wrong.

This fight—today's disaster—wasn't over.

Not until one particular person was dead for good.

"Let's go."

—…Human.

"We have to finish it."

At my voice, which slipped through cracked lips, the guardian spirit seemed about to answer. Instead, it pushed its heavy body forward.

Whoosh!

Wind swept over me.

At the end of the road we were traveling, one person was struggling to live despite vomiting blood.

No.

There was a monster.

Chapter 707

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress could not understand.

How had the grand plan she'd been so sure was perfect fallen apart? And why had she been reduced to the humiliation of fighting a mere member of the Ten Kings on equal terms?

But she had no time to dwell on it.

Whoosh!

A fierce rush of air drowned out the wind.

A massive figure surged forward, erasing the space around it. Green Fist Force erupted from the Beast Miao King's fist, illuminating the world.

Kraaaaaaash!

Not long ago—just two shichen[3004] ago—the Southern Heaven Demon Empress would have snorted and knocked that Fist Force aside.

The Beast Miao King was one of the Ten Kings. He might even have been underestimated because he was from Nanman. But he was still unmistakably a step below her.

He had been.

Until someone's strike took one of her arms and tore away part of her side.

Jin Taekyung.

Merely thinking the name filled her with rage.

Gritting her teeth, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress stepped forward and vanished. The Beast Miao King realized his attack had missed and reacted at once.

Whoosh!

He stood over eight cheok[3005] tall, yet he moved like the wind. His tiger eyes, streaming with flame, were already fixed on the Southern Heaven Demon Empress as she rushed toward his side.

Shwaaak!

His hand, as large as a tiger's forepaw, raked across the air.

Slice!

Blade-sharp wind cut the hem of her robe. In the same instant, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress leaped in close and drove a palm toward him with all her strength.

Whoosh!

The blow should have crushed flesh and burst bones and organs.

Instead, her small, blood-drenched hand met the Beast Miao King's palm—several times larger than her own.

[3004] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

[3005] A cheok is about 30.3 cm (11.9 in); eight cheok are about 2.42 m (7.95 ft).

Boom!

The world shook. Murky internal energy, as though laced with deadly poison, flowed through the point where their palms met and churned the Beast Miao King's insides.

He swallowed the blood rising in his throat and grinned.

"So this is all you've got?"

"…!"

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress's eyes widened.

It was unbelievable. That the Beast Miao King could smile even in a situation like this.

And that her full-strength palm strike had become so pathetically weak.

Blood slipped between her clenched teeth. Then her figure blurred.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh—boom!

Compressed air burst outward with each sharp report.

In an instant, her hands and feet struck all over the Beast Miao King's body like flashes of lightning, jolting his massive frame.

But that was all.

Long years of training in the external arts had made his body as tough as steel. Her blows should long since have left him vomiting blood on his knees, yet they no longer carried their former weight.

No. They were growing weaker.

The demonic qi from the rift was strengthening her, but it could not undo the terrible injuries Jin Taekyung had inflicted. Nor could it steady the mental strength those injuries had shaken.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress realized it before anyone else.

…Tired? Me?

Everything had a limit. At some point, she had forgotten hers. How could she not have? For so many years, no one had pushed her far enough to feel it.

Until now.

Whoosh—crack!

The relentless rush of her attacks stopped. Pain shot through her hand.

Crack.

Bones shifted in the small fist that should have smashed into his chest and burst his heart. The Beast Miao King had caught it in his enormous palm.

He bared his bloodstained teeth.

"I told you. I'd tear off your limbs and kill you."

"…!"

His cold voice cut into her ears. Blood vessels burst in her eyes as she stared at him.

She instinctively reached out with her other hand to seize the Beast Miao King by the throat. But then she saw the green Fist Force filling her vision and realized—

Ah.

Someone else had already taken that arm.

Boom!

The world turned upside down. Flung away like a cannonball, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress felt her vision dim.

In the slowed-down world, light and darkness flashed endlessly before her eyes. The sky and the earth traded places, twisting together.

Then came an impact that threatened to grind her entire body to powder.

Kraaaaaaang!

She tore through the mound of Inner Palace ruins and crashed deep into its center, vomiting blood.

“Kweh-heeeeeck!”

Splash!

Dark. Red.

Dark-red blood mixed with pieces of internal organs sprayed across the countless large and small fragments scattered in every direction.

She felt her body trembling along with the horrible pain.

This… This can’t be happening. It can’t.

As that single thought filled her mind, something came into her blurred view.

Thud. Thud.

The rubble shifted. Someone staggered upright beneath it.

Hope glimmered in her unsteady eyes.

That was it. Hope.

“M-Me. Hurry, take me…”

Her voice was barely more than a breath. She reached out a trembling hand toward the figure slowly rising on two legs bent at unnatural angles.

Toward her loyal subordinate, his torn-open neck hanging limp as he awaited a recovery that defied even the words *supernatural powers*.

“Hurry. Take me as far away from here as you can…”

At this moment, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was more desperate than anyone else in the world.

Her grand plan had achieved only half its aim. Death, which she had never once imagined for herself, loomed before her.

She had to escape. She wanted to live, even if fleeing was the only way. As long as she survived, she could plan what came next.

She could return and carry on her grand plan—her revenge—somewhere else.

But her last hope died as a shadow fell over the Masked Man's head.

Whoosh. Crack!

It was not the Beast Miao King, Jin Taekyung, or anyone else.

It was simply a massive boulder.

It had probably been dislodged by the force of the impact.

Somewhere in the ruins piled up like a mountain—perhaps even the foundation stone of the Nanman Beast Palace—a massive stone weighing a thousand geun[3006] crashed down over the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's final hope.

The Masked Man, who had lost his reason long ago and now did nothing but obey his master's commands, was crushed beneath the boulder. His limbs twitched.

She stared blankly at him. Then footsteps like thunder reached her ears.

Thud. Thud.

A footfall approached over blood-soaked ground, treading on sand and rubble.

No. Footsteps.

No strange cries or clashing weapons accompanied those unusually loud steps.

Ah.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress raised her head and finally understood.

The fierce battle for the fate of this land—for Nanman—was over.

And along with it, the fate she had carried forward for so many years was also nearing its end.

At the head of the approaching group was the person who had created this entire situation.

Thud.

A blood-soaked beast's forepaw stepped over the rubble.

The enormous White Tiger stopped three jang[3007] away. On its back sat a man whose face she never wanted to see again, not even in a dream.

"Feels like I haven't seen you in a while… You've gotten a lot prettier."

Whoosh! Thud!

The Finger Qi she fired on instinct grazed Jin Taekyung's shoulder and pierced the rubble behind him.

He casually rubbed the blood flowing from the cut, then licked his palm, wet with blood.

"Thanks. I was thirsty anyway. Is this what they mean by a grandmother's love?"

"…!"

Blood welled up between her clenched teeth.

[3006] A Korean geun is about 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun are about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

[3007] A jang is ten cheok, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft); three jang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

She gathered every scrap of strength and tried to rise. A dozen or so assault spears flew over Jin Taekyung's head.

Whiiiiiiish—boom!

She knocked aside the Baekcheon Unit's spears with a single sweep of her hand, then glared at him, the blood vessels in her eyes bursting.

"How dare you!"

Fwooooooosh!

Her voice, charged with internal energy, shook the air around them. She had lost an arm and suffered severe Internal Injury, but the demonic qi flowing from the rift still lent her power.

But…

Not enough.

Even so, she could not overturn the current situation.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress understood that better than anyone. She knew the desperate reality that had befallen her.

When she saw the Beast Miao King beside Jin Taekyung, she was certain.

I'm going to die.

With her body in ruins, there was nothing she could do. Even if she somehow escaped, thousands of Nanman warriors waited outside.

Certain death.

The words closed around her with a weight she had never imagined. Every thought vanished; the turmoil in her mind fell still.

Then a low hiss of air broke the silence.

Whoosh!

The Beast Miao King. The guardian spirit. Jin Taekyung.

As though they had planned it, all three surged forward like a single gust of wind. They would give her no opening, not even a moment for final words.

They had only one resolve: to cut off the breath of the Fiend known as the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Kraaaaaaaash!

Green Fist Force bore down on the air. Bloodstained teeth tore through the wind. A transparent spearhead, carrying one last handful of internal energy, burned with blue-white hellfire.

She saw it all.

A faint light entered the empty eyes of the old woman who had lost the beauty once called the greatest in the world, as she watched death rush toward her.

Lord of Heaven.

The noblest, most exalted being in the world.

Long ago, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had loved him from the moment she first saw him. She had prostrated herself at his feet and sworn her loyalty.

She would offer her insignificant life for him.

Even if her youth and beauty faded someday, she had promised to remain by his side forever, even if only from a distance.

She had not known then that the day she would give her life would come so soon. Or that a day would come when she could no longer remain near the Lord of Heaven she revered.

But…

Please remember that this lowly woman stood beside you.

If the Lord of Heaven remembered her as a servant who had loved him more than anyone, that would be enough.

If he did, she could gladly burn through the life she had left with a smile.

Just as she was doing at this very moment.

Crack.

In the slowed world, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress heard the rift—a sound only she could hear.

Innate qi.

The purest, most powerful force she had carried since birth awakened. An immense energy surged through her body and gathered in her hand.

Gooooooooong.

Space twisted as though invisible hands were tearing it apart. At the shock on the three faces before her, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled.

No. She tried to.

Thud!

Until a sword thrust out from the heap of ruins behind her and buried itself in her back, emerging from the deep, dark gap between the fallen stones.

Chapter 708

Thrust!

The unmistakable sound of a blade piercing flesh reached the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's ears, and the world around her stopped.

All she could feel was the cold blade driven deep into her back.

Why? Who? How?

Questions crowded her mind through the distant pain.

Instinct moved her before reason could. She spun at lightning speed and thrust out a palm.

Whoosh!

Innate qi. A portion of the immense internal energy gathered in her hand struck the collapsed ruins.

Kraaaaaaash!

Thousands upon thousands of geun[3008] of rubble exploded outward with a tremendous roar.

Among the flying fragments was the answer to her questions.

"Kugh!"

A figure was flung helplessly away by the blast.

One sleeve of his blood- and dust-stained white robe hung empty. Blood gushed from the wound in his chest, an injury beyond recovery.

But his cold, steady gaze remained fixed on the Southern Heaven Demon Empress until the very end.

His eyes, filled with rage and regret beyond measure, seemed to tell her he had waited a very long time for this moment.

"Baeksang…!"

His name burst from her lips like a scream. At the same instant, she felt wind rushing at her from behind, and her eyes widened.

Shwaaaaaak!

Baeksang's unexpected strike had cost her no more than a moment.

But that single blink had given someone else an advantage—and dealt her a terrible blow.

Crack.

Swallowing the thick blood in her mouth, she wrenched the sword from her back and turned at lightning speed.

Three figures swept toward her like a gale.

The Beast Miao King. The guardian spirit. Jin Taekyung.

[3008] A Korean geun is 600 g, or about 1.32 lb.

At the sight of them, the qi and blood Baeksang's strike had thrown into turmoil convulsed inside her.

She felt the flame of mutual destruction, kindled with her own life as fuel, flicker like a candle in the wind.

Pain surged through her again. Her vision blurred.

She could not stop. She must not stop.

Kill.

Clinging to that single thought, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress gritted her teeth and extended her hand.

Toward the three figures already upon her. Toward the enemies who dared obstruct the great work the exalted Lord of Heaven sought to accomplish.

Goooooooooong.

In the slowed world, immense energy flowed through her blood-soaked hand and into the blade. The sword, now in its new master's grasp, swept down at an angle.

Shwaaaaaak!

Through the warping space, she saw three pairs of eyes slowly widen. Green Force surged up like an iron wall to shield them all.

But…

It's over.

With that thought, unheard by anyone else, a blinding flash swallowed everything.

Fwooooooosh!

No one in that land had ever seen an explosion like it.

Fwoom! Ruuuuumble!

Yohi and Muyaho saw it as they evacuated the survivors alongside countless wild beasts.

The thousands of warriors surrounding the darkened Inner Palace saw it, their blood-soaked weapons held ready.

So did the tribespeople running toward the hills beyond the Outer Palace, gasping for breath.

One word came to them all.

A cataclysm.

Nothing else could describe it. The blinding flash and violent tremors reached far beyond the Inner Palace. Everyone who felt their force froze.

No—they trembled with a fear that seemed to bind their very souls.

"A-Aah…!"

The groans rising from every direction all turned toward one place: the Nanman Beast Palace they had left behind.

Boom. Rumble.

It was collapsing.

The pavilions and homes their ancestors had spent long years building with blood and sweat—the place where they had been born and raised—were on the verge of collapsing before their eyes.

What more was there to say?

Thousands upon thousands stared at the Nanman Beast Palace, trying to take in one last sight of their beloved home before it was lost to them forever.

But soon, their despair gave way to hope.

Ruuuuumble…

The tremors gradually subsided. The ground stopped collapsing before it could swallow the Nanman Beast Palace whole. The houses and pavilions that had swayed on the brink of falling remained standing, though they leaned.

An unimaginable disaster. Then a miracle.

The people who witnessed it were overcome with relief and joy. But the person who had unleashed that disaster with nothing more than a human body shook with pain and rage.

“T-This can’t… Kueeegh!”

Drip. Drip.

Dark-red blood spilled down from the corner of her mouth.

Everything within a radius of fifty jang[3009] had been shattered and hurled away. Standing in the empty space left behind, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress looked around with blood-red eyes.

One strike. One sure chance.

She had not cared if it killed her. There was no returning alive now, and even if she lived, she would have to spend the rest of her days in this old, hideous body.

And yet she had survived.

She should have been blown apart and killed in the explosion, after swallowing everything in its path. Instead, she had survived. The humiliation burned.

“Baeksang! You bastard. How dare you!”

Rumble!

A wave of qi burst from her with the roar, shaking the space around her.

Baeksang’s unexpected strike. That single thrust of his sword, made with what must have been the last of his strength, had changed everything.

The turmoil it caused within her had kept her from pouring all her innate qi into the attack. She had escaped death in the explosion because of it.

[3009] A jang is about 3.03 m, or 9.94 ft. Fifty jang is about 152 m, or 497 ft.

So had *they*.

"Cough."

Thud.

Several dozen jang[3010] away, a graying giant dropped to one knee and vomited blood mixed with pieces of his organs.

Countless fragments studded his body. Behind his broad back, she saw the enormous White Tiger and a young man lying drenched in blood.

"Yayul Cheok, you bastard…!"

Blood and phlegm rattled in her throat. The Beast Miao King's actions in the final instant flashed through her mind.

He had stepped in front of Jin Taekyung without the slightest hesitation.

Why?

She could not understand why Yayul Cheok, who had earned a place among the Ten Kings in the distant Central Plains, would make that choice.

And that stinking beast had done the same.

Risk their only lives? For a mere brat?

The question brought her one certainty.

Jin Taekyung. I have to kill him, whatever it takes.

The Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, a man little different from the king of a nation, and the White Tiger that bore a divine artifact had risked their lives for him. That made him the one person here with the most dangerous potential.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress still had innate qi she had not spent.

The last strength bought by burning her life.

Lord of Heaven. Please forgive this disloyal servant for daring to defy your will.

Step.

She took a heavy step, and a sharp sound of splitting air rang out.

Shk! Crack!

A spear that had flown from somewhere trembled in her grasp. She crushed its steel spearhead in her bare hand, her eyes glowing blood-red.

"Do you all want to die?"

A middle-aged man stood where her cold words were directed, his armor torn almost to shreds.

And he was not alone.

Drip. Thud.

Across the devastated ground, more than a hundred warriors staggered to their feet and gathered behind him, gripping swords and spears.

[3010] A jang is about 3.03 m, or 9.94 ft. Fifty jang is about 152 m, or 497 ft.

Though they had been farther from the center of the blast, every one of them bore wounds. They stood in her way to fulfill the mission entrusted to them.

Splash.

The middle-aged man lifted something from a pool of blood and bound it tightly around his forehead. His gaze remained steady on the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Three characters were written on the old silk, still legible beneath the blood.

Baekcheon Unit.

That was his answer to her question. It was Wang Ho's answer as Commander of the Baekcheon Unit, and the resolve of every surviving member.

The next moment—

Screeeeeech! Boom!

The Fiend known as the Southern Heaven Demon Empress charged at them.

A flash of light. An explosion.

Those were the last things I remembered. I'd thought that when I opened my eyes again, everything would be over.

I'd be alive. Or I'd be dead.

A battle could only end one of those two ways.

But when I opened my eyes after a brief spell of darkness, I realized I'd been only half right.

I was alive. The battle wasn't over.

Kraaaaaack!

"Gaaaaah!"

"Stop her—!"

Slice!

"Noooo!"

My senses returned, and I saw blood spraying into the sky. Severed limbs flew after it. Someone's body, crushed into a bloody pulp by overwhelming force, hurtled away.

Whoom! Boom!

Drip.

Blood splashed across my face from only a few steps away.

I stared blankly at a warrior lying dead with a hole through the center of his chest. Then a weak voice reached me.

No. It was someone's thought.

—Human.

Only then did I realize what was supporting my back, and whose warmth I felt.

The thick smell of blood filled my nose. I turned my head and lost my words.

"…!"

A massive body trembled now and then in a deep pool of blood.

The silver fur I'd once thought almost mystical was soaked through. Pale blue eyes blinked at me with visible effort.

—You've slept a long time.

"…What is this?"

—I have no regrets. Neither does he.

At the moment that distant flash had filled my vision, there had been green Force and a silver mane blocking my eyes.

No way.

As usual, my worst suspicion was right.

I turned and saw a broad back. The man kneeling there, so drenched in blood he scarcely looked human, was the Beast Miao King, Yayul Cheok.

He was unconscious. Fragments of the sword were embedded all over his body. He must have taken them while shielding someone else.

"This is insane. Why the hell…?"

—Go.

"What?"

—Leave. Hurry. There's no time.

The guardian spirit turned its head with difficulty and spat something out.

Fwooooooosh.

The sacred stone, now no larger than a child's fist, gave off a faint light.

I understood what it meant and gritted my teeth.

"Don't give me that bullshit."

—If they fall too, you are next. But if you run, you can survive.

Kraaaaaack!

"Gaaaaaaaah!"

The ground shook, and another scream followed. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress entered my field of vision, her veins standing out across her entire body as she burned through the last of her life and tore apart more than a hundred members of the Baekcheon Unit.

"…!"

A chill swept over me at the sight of that overwhelming power. As I froze in place, the guardian spirit whispered with all its strength.

—Go. Now!

I knew it was right. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress didn’t have much time left. If I ran alone, I could survive.

But…

I’d regret it for the rest of my life.

I muttered dazedly and grabbed the sacred stone.

Then I rose and ran.

Not toward the Outer Palace.

Toward the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Chapter 709

Screeeeeech!

Jin Taekyung wavered slightly as he shot forward at breakneck speed.

His limbs, usually as light as down, hung heavy and ached. Every step felt incomparably heavier than before.

One Annihilation had taken a terrible toll. Without the Beast Miao King's help, Jin would not have been able to stand, much less run. And even if he had somehow stayed on his feet, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's devastating attack would have killed him.

And yet… he had survived.

The Beast Miao King and the guardian spirit had risked their lives to save him when he had the least strength left to spare. Now the Baekcheon Unit was carrying on their resolve, staking their lives at this very moment.

Charging into the darkness. Toward a Fiend they had no power to stop.

Crack!

One strike.

The Fiend's blood-soaked hand crushed bone and flesh, then punched through a chest.

An unnamed life went out. Someone else stepped forward to fill the gap.

Why?

Jin Taekyung did not know them. They did not know him.

Yet every one of them was willing to throw away their life. They filled the places left by comrades dying one after another and charged toward a death they could not stop.

The sight of the Baekcheon Unit overlapped with that of someone who had forced a smile in a dark cave.

Go on ahead, Taekyung.

Jin had survived because he ran. Because he had survived, he had regretted it countless times. If he could return to that moment, he would say—

"I'm not going. Never."

At the words forced through his clenched teeth, Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit, turned his head.

Drenched in blood that might not have been his own, Wang Ho stared at the figure rapidly closing in.

Jin Taekyung should not be here.

The Beast Miao King, Wang Ho, and the hundred warriors of the Baekcheon Unit had risked their lives to buy him this precious time. Surely his one task was to survive, whatever it took.

Instead, he had come running straight back into danger.

“What the hell is going on…!”

As Wang Ho cried out and moved to block Jin Taekyung, a hand planted firmly on his shoulder. A low voice sounded beside his ear.

“Let’s get out of this alive together.”

“…!”

“Fuck. I said let’s *survive* together!”

Wang Ho went rigid.

He could find no words for that cry—not *let’s die together*, but *let’s survive together*—or for Jin’s eyes, burning like fire and wet with tears.

He could not stop the young man from leaving him behind and running toward death.

And then he understood why the Beast Miao King, his lord, who had nearly a hundred thousand tribespeople to lead, had made his choice.

Was this why? Was it because of this very sight that you wanted to protect that young man more than your own safety?

If Jin had returned so they could die together, it would have been nothing more than foolhardy courage.

But Jin Taekyung had come back to fight beside them. To save as many people as they could—even one more—and for all of them to survive.

Tsstsst!

The Sword Energy that had seemed about to gutter out blazed stronger. Wang Ho raised his blade, sheathed in blue qi, and charged.

He shouted to his subordinates, fewer than half of whom remained.

“Kill that Fiend!”

It was a small difference in resolve, and an enormous one.

Hold her back? Or kill her?

Until now, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had been someone they could not kill with the strength they had. No—they had *believed* they could not kill her and accepted their deaths.

Not anymore.

Now they were fighting to kill the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. Fighting to survive.

At the center of it all was the young man who had made them see the difference.

“Southern Heaven Demon Empress!”

Jin Taekyung roared in fury. A faint flame sprang from his toes.

Boom!

A small explosion cratered the ground, cracks spreading through it like a spiderweb. The recoil hurled him forward even faster.

Ahead of him stood the Fiend, steeped in blood and darkness.

Slice! Shraaaaaak!

A hand blade wreathed in murky darkness split someone in two.

Beyond the blood spraying in every direction, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress saw Jin Taekyung tearing through space as he charged toward her—and smiled delightedly.

Foolish child. Your recklessness has given me one last chance.

Until a moment ago, she had been furious. The innate qi bought with her life was dwindling by the moment, and the hundred Baekcheon Unit warriors blocking her path had worn away her remaining strength even as they died.

But now she could smile. Her most important prey had come searching for the place where he would die, foolishly walking there on his own two feet.

"Now, you small fry… get out of my way."

Roooooar!

Murky palm Force swept through the warriors blocking her path. They flew in every direction, coughing blood.

A sound split the air across the space they left behind.

Screeeeeech! Boom!

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress knocked away an iron spear that shot toward her like a flash of light with her bare hand, then swung down with her hand blade.

Whoooosh!

Space split, and a blade-sharp wind tore through it.

But Jin Taekyung was nowhere to be seen.

Above!

As she realized it, her figure blurred. A transparent spearhead slashed down from overhead and cut through her afterimage.

Slice!

No—not only her afterimage.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress felt a drop of blood roll down her forehead. Her expression tightened slightly.

Fast.

In a way, it was only natural. A martial artist who had reached the Supreme Peak was more than worthy of being called superhuman.

But martial insight alone did not make them superhuman. They also possessed vast reserves of internal energy, which heightened the physical abilities they had honed over years of training.

Then how…?

Jin Taekyung had used up most of his internal energy. How could he still move with such speed and strength?

Shk-shk-shk-shk!

The spear tip trembled. Dozens of spear shadows spread out and rained down on her entire body.

Their speed and force far exceeded anything she had expected. But she did not retreat.

“How dare you, you little brat…!”

Her voice seethed as her one remaining hand shot through the air. Her palm strike, stained with the blood of countless warriors, swallowed the spear shadows bearing down on her.

Roooooar!

No matter how many falsehoods there were, in the end, only one truth would emerge.

The shadows vanished in the palm Force. Her hand, shrouded in murky darkness, closed around the transparent spearhead.

Slice!

Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, said to be harder and sharper than anything under heaven, tore through her Force and cut into her flesh.

Pain struck. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress smiled anyway.

I’ve got it.

At that moment—

Shwaaaaaaak!

Her qi flowed along the spearhead and swept through Jin Taekyung’s insides.

Boom!

“…!”

His body jerked. The injuries within him, briefly calmed by the Beast Miao King’s help, were thrown into turmoil again.

Jin swallowed the blood rising in his throat and tightened his grip on the spear shaft.

Crack!

The White Flame’s spearhead twisted in her grasp and drove farther forward. Her hand was shredded in an instant. Her eyes widened at the pain.

“You…”

Before she could finish, a sharp sound cut through the air.

Shiiiiing!

A sword flew through the wind. Its owner, wrapped in blue Sword Energy, was none other than Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit.

Slice!

She twisted away, but too late. Her Body-Protecting Qi, far weaker than before, could not stop the Sword Energy. Pain shot through her slashed flank, and she kicked upward.

Screeeeeech—crack!

Her foot struck Wang Ho's abdomen like a whip. He flew more than ten jang[3011], hurtling away like a cannonball.

Boom!

Dust billowed from the impact.

But Wang Ho was not the only one charging her.

Pat-pat-pat!

Figures rushed in from front and back, left and right, surrounding the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Fewer than twenty warriors of the Baekcheon Unit remained. They gathered the last of their strength and charged—to end this fight, to drive their spears and blades into the Fiend even if it cost them their lives.

Shk-shk-shk-shk!

At that moment, when the fierce sounds of weapons tearing through the air mingled with the wind—

Kraaaaaash!

Energy burst outward like a storm, sweeping away everything coming at her from every side.

And from between the lips of the person standing tall at its center, blood that could no longer be held back began to flow.

Cough.

Through dimming vision, she looked with trembling eyes at the young man kneeling before her.

His gaze was faint, as though its light might go out at any moment. But his hands did not shake. They gripped the spear shaft and held it thrust forward, its transparent head driven into her chest.

"Guh…!"

She coughed up dark-red blood and gasped for air.

She had needed to stop him. She had thought she could.

She had failed.

How? How could he still move?

Just before she unleashed her palm Force at the warriors, she had sent internal energy into Jin Taekyung again—to ensure that this time he would never rise, that his breath would stop for good.

[3011] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). More than ten *jang* is more than about 30 meters (100 ft).

But he had not fallen. He had not died.

Even though his heart meridian had undoubtedly been torn to shreds, he had driven the spear he had held until the very end into the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's chest.

"Jin Tae…kyung."

Her broken voice had barely left her lips when—

Slide. Thud.

Jin Taekyung's blood-soaked hands slipped from the shaft. His head fell back, and his eyes grew hazy.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress felt it then. She could hear it, too: death approaching Jin Taekyung, slowly but surely.

And his voice, impossibly bright for a man so close to death.

"Finally got you, you… fucking bitch."

"…!"

Every hair on her body seemed to stand on end.

It was fear. Terror of a human being whose resolve would not waver, no matter what happened.

…Afraid? I'm afraid? Me? Of that bastard?

Impossible. She could not fear anyone but the Lord of Heaven—least of all a mere brat on the brink of death.

I have to kill him. I have to stop his breath with my own hand.

She raised her hand slowly, the thought repeating in a daze.

She would likely die too. But unless she killed Jin Taekyung herself, she felt she would never rest in peace, even in death.

Die.

You monster.

With those words she did not have the chance to spit out, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress swung down her hand blade with the last of her strength.

Shk!

And at the moment the murky darkness was about to bore into the crown of Jin Taekyung's head—

Screeeeeech! Crack!

A streak of light flew in from somewhere and swallowed her only remaining arm.

A cold voice reached her as she froze.

"Just whose body do you think you're laying a hand on, you fucking bitch?"

Chapter 710

He could feel it. Death was right before his eyes.

His blurred vision could barely make out shapes. His once-sharp senses seemed ready to leave his body.

In the darkness of his fading consciousness, Jin Taekyung thought:

No doubt about it.

This is a dream. Or maybe I'm hearing things because I'm about to die.

How else could he explain the voice behind him?

"Just whose body do you think you're laying a hand on, you fucking bitch?"

And yet… it sounded so much like him.

That sharp voice, almost shrill with irritation. Those foul-mouthed curses. Both brought one person to mind. Taekyung knew that person could not possibly be here, and he scolded himself for even thinking it. Still, he couldn't help hoping.

I really must be dying.

The hollow thought echoed through his mind.

"So… how long are you going to sit there in a daze?"

"…!"

Jin Taekyung's eyelids, which had been slowly closing, stopped abruptly.

The shock jolted him awake, and his distant senses rushed back.

No way.

No. It can't be.

It was impossible. *He* was supposed to be somewhere far away in the Central Plains.

But someone had once said that hope could break a person—and raise them up again. Taekyung clung to that invisible thread and opened his eyes.

"Ah. Aah…"

He saw the Southern Heaven Demon Empress staggering, both arms gone.

And a single Zen staff planted at an angle beside her as she stood gripped by shock and confusion.

Clatter.

The rings hanging from it rattled loudly. The staff glowed red, and Taekyung could feel the Scorching Yang Qi flowing from it. A faint smile touched his lips.

"You… could've come a little sooner."

He spoke so softly that anyone else would have needed to stand right beside him to hear.

But the owner of the staff was different. He could have heard Taekyung from

hundreds of jang[3012] away—hundreds of li,[3013] even.

Not with his ears.

With his heart. With the heart he held for his one and only Disciple.

“I’m allowed to be a little late. No need to give me grief, you brat.”

His gruff answer betrayed none of what he felt. Blood Monk—no, Fire King Jeok Cheongang—took a step forward.

Thud.

And the next moment—

Whoosh!

In the blackout that followed the end of the performance, a flame rose, larger and fiercer than anything else on the stage.

Kraaaaaash!

Flame Divine Palm.

A wave of fire surged through the darkness, devouring it with terrible heat. It rushed on without slowing, with only one purpose: to burn the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Ah.

She watched it approach with empty eyes.

No groan or scream escaped her. Her feet might as well have been nailed to the ground, and the pain where her arms had been felt strangely distant.

I have to dodge. Somehow, I have to dodge…

Her body would not obey the cry in her head.

Perhaps it had all ended the moment she lost her one remaining arm. The Zen staff had flown so fast it could have been mistaken for a flash of light, carrying enough heat to turn more than her arm to ash.

Her innate qi.

It had stripped away the last handful of strength she had saved to bring one person’s life to an end. Indifferently. Mercilessly.

Watching herself stand there without the strength to take even one step, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress finally understood.

It’s over.

Her life had been long indeed. She no longer knew exactly where it had begun, but here, today, it would end.

If she had one regret, it was that she had failed to stop Jin Taekyung’s breath with her own hand.

But… that’s all right.

[3012] A jang is ten cheok, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3013] A Chinese li is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

She did not know why Fire King Jeok Cheongang had come here, or what trick of fate had brought him.

But just as she would die here, Jin Taekyung could not escape death either. Not even the Great Firmament Immortal could change that.

The certainty comforted her as she accepted the flames.

Lord of Heaven.

The invocation sounded softly within her heart.

Her thoughts had been long, but only an instant had passed. The flames shot over Taekyung's kneeling head and opened their maw toward her.

Whoooosh!

As the light-flames poured down, melting the darkness, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress closed her eyes.

No—she tried to.

She would have succeeded if, just as everything turned white, someone had not thrown himself onto her body, which no longer had the strength to move a finger.

Whump!

In that split instant, she saw him clearly.

"…!"

Jin Taekyung's face was deathly pale. In a world moving impossibly slowly, his lips parted.

And then—

Crack!

Sharp pain shot through her throat, and her vision went dark.

The realization struck like a flash of light. It was an inescapable fact.

If the Southern Heaven Demon Empress dies now, I die too.

The main reason I'd survived fights against people stronger than me was the recovery I got when I leveled up.

Even with outstanding Muscles and Bones and all the stats I'd raised, I couldn't survive certain death. Not with my acupoints wrecked and my duodenum on leave from its post like a soldier who'd wandered outside his assigned area.

If someone else killed the Southern Heaven Demon Empress now, I was fucked.

That left me one choice.

Tank it.

Fuck.

I swallowed the curse and squeezed out every last bit of strength to throw myself forward.

No—it would be more accurate to say that I barely managed to raise my body and throw myself over the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

Whump!

"…!"

Her eyes, closing in resignation, snapped wide open. Shock and confusion swirled in them, asking the question she could not voice.

Why?

I had no reason to answer, and no time.

If I'd had the strength, I would have picked up White Flame from where it had fallen a few steps away. Or pulled another weapon from my Inventory and driven it into her heart.

But damn it, I could barely hold on to consciousness. This was the best attack I had left.

Crack!

Wrinkled skin mottled with age spots tore away. The taste of blood filled my mouth and wet my parched lips.

Of all the attacks I'd made in all the battles I'd fought, this was the most primitive. And I had never needed one to work more badly.

I tore a mouthful from the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's throat.

Then I felt tremendous heat at my back and heard someone scream.

"No—!"

Whoosh! Boom!

A massive impact slammed into me. A roar swallowed the rest of the cry, and terrible heat swept out in every direction. I felt weightless for an instant before it hurled me away.

Ah.

Who was it who said that the worst pain a person could feel was being burned?

They were right.

Pain too awful to scream through seized my entire body. My vision went white. I couldn't see an inch in front of me as I hurtled through the air.

Screeeeeech—boom!

The rushing wind seemed to go on forever. Then something rough and hard struck my whole body.

No. My body had shot through the rubble like a beam of light and buried itself there.

Cough.

With a cough, what little blood I had left trickled from the corner of my mouth.

My eardrums had burst, yet I heard a swarm of bees buzzing in my ears. Through my blurred vision, I could make out the Southern Heaven Demon Empress sprawled on the ground and someone's figure wavering like a heat haze.

"No!"

At that scream—

Ding.

A clear bell rang in my ear, and warmth enveloped me.

Screeeeeech!

Jeok Cheongang raced forward with all his strength, his heart full of despair.

No. No, this can't happen.

Every step felt heavy.

His heart, aged by more than a century, pounded harder than it ever had. His eyes trembled, fixed on the person rapidly drawing closer.

Jin Taekyung.

The second Disciple he had taken in his lifetime, and the only one he had left.

The one ember that had appeared in the life of a man who had wished only for death and shown him a reason to keep living.

But why? Why the hell would he do that?

He felt as though he might cough up blood.

What he had unleashed at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress was the Flame Divine Palm, driven to a staggering twelve-tenths of its normal limit.

And Jin Taekyung had suddenly blocked that horrifying heat, powerful enough to melt steel.

You crazy bastard. You stupid bastard!

Jeok Cheongang did not know why. The reason did not matter. The curses he could not bring himself to shout were meant for himself.

His one and only Disciple had always had a reason for his choices. He had always been right.

It was the grief and guilt of knowing his own hasty judgment had cost Taekyung his life that tore Jeok Cheongang's heart apart.

"No!"

The old master's desperate cry rang out as he finally stopped before his Disciple.

"Taekyung! You bastard!"

There was no answer.

Taekyung lay with his eyes closed, his breathing so faint it could stop at any moment. Jeok Cheongang's heart sank.

Ah.

His vision swam.

Taekyung's armor was shattered beyond recognition. His limbs lay twisted at unnatural angles. Beneath the heat of the Flame Divine Palm, flesh had melted and bone had broken.

Perhaps the armor had saved him. Somehow, he was still breathing.

But only just. He had mere moments left.

Even if Jeok Cheongang poured all his internal energy into him, it would not change that. It would only prolong the pain.

Tap.

His hand stopped in midair, trembling as he reached for Taekyung's wrist to take his pulse.

…Dying? He's dying? That boy?

Unable to watch Taekyung die before his eyes, Jeok Cheongang squeezed his eyes shut.

He had seen countless deaths. Some he had witnessed from afar. Others he had caused with his own hands.

But… Jin Taekyung's death was different.

The boy had barely passed twenty. Unlike Jeok Cheongang, he had so many years left to live, so much happiness still to enjoy.

"What… what could be so urgent that you have to leave already? Why!"

Jeok Cheongang cried out as though the words were tearing blood from him.

He held Jin Taekyung's hand, which had been half melted by his own martial arts. Holding that hand, still bearing the marks of those horrific injuries, he wept his heart out…

Huh?

Something felt strange beneath his fingers. He opened his eyes.

Through his tears, he saw Taekyung's hand.

The back of it was pale and smooth as a newborn baby's. Its veins stood out in thick ridges.

"…?"

That was strange. A moment ago, the flesh had been melted together. He was almost sure he had seen bone.

What the hell?

There were only two possibilities. Either those damned infirmities of old age had returned, or…

Gulp.

Jeok Cheongang swallowed and slowly raised his head.

A pair of eyes was watching him with interest.

“…?”
“…?”
“…!”
“…!”
They stared at each other. Jeok Cheongang froze.
Facing him, Jin Taekyung wiggled his fingers sheepishly.
“Um, could you let go of my hand first? Then we can talk.”

Chapter 711

Sometimes, a certain kind of silence can take the place of countless emotions and words.

Like right now.

“Um, could you let go of my hand first? Then we can talk.”

“…”

Jeok Cheongang did not let go. He did not answer, either. He only stared, his gaze roaming over my face and the rest of me as if he were in a daze.

What the hell? Is this all a dream?

That was what his eyes seemed to say, and I understood completely.

How else could he react?

The guy who had been dying right in front of him was suddenly alive and whole.

Even that prophet from the neighborhood over had wounds on his palms after rising from the dead three days after being nailed to a cross. Five level-ups had left me with the unblemished skin of a baby.

And Jeok Cheongang had watched it happen.

Smack!

A sharp sound rang out.

Jeok Cheongang had slapped himself across the face with all his strength. He blinked at me, then spoke with a grave expression.

“Let me ask you one thing. Am I dreaming?”

I answered carefully. “No.”

“No matter how I think about it, this feels like a dream.”

“Then slap yourself again.”

Smack!

No hesitation, as usual.

He must have hit himself pretty damn hard. Jeok Cheongang spat out a thick mouthful of blood, then took a deep breath.

“…Damn it. Not a dream. Then is this an illusion cast by a Mystic Gate Formation?”

“Uh, I don’t think so. If I were an illusion, whose hand would the Old Master be holding right now?”

“A Dark Heaven sorcerer wearing your likeness. Or the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, if she isn’t dead after all. Whoever it is, they’ll be preparing a One Strike while I’m distracted by the illusion.”

“Quite an imagination you’ve got. Are you going senile?”

“The way you speak certainly sounds like you. Hah. This is driving me mad.”

“It’s driving me mad too.”

I meant it. I had kept the System hidden all this time, and now I had been caught with no way to explain it away.

I sighed and looked at Jeok Cheongang, who still seemed stunned. No matter how many times I looked, I could not get used to his roughly shaved head and worn monk's robe.

"Anyway, what's with that getup?"

"Can't you tell? It's a disguise. I look enough like a monk, don't I?"

"You look like a monk who broke his vows, set fire to a temple, and ran away."

"…You little bastard. Do you think I wanted to dress up as some fake monk? I had to stay out of Dark Heaven's sight. My hair stood out too much, so I shaved it off."

Fair enough. No matter how vast the world was, red hair was rare. He would stand out wherever he went, and word would spread.

But that did not explain everything.

The Blood Monk I had heard about was a terrifying fiend who had single-handedly drenched Guangxi in blood.

"So, to avoid Dark Heaven, you disguised yourself as a monk and beat hundreds of innocent Murim practitioners to death?"

"What those bastards were doing was—what?"

Jeok Cheongang's brow furrowed as he tried to continue.

"Innocent Murim practitioners? What nonsense is that?"

"…?"

"I did draw attention in Guangxi, though I never meant to. Some unorthodox faction scum were taking advantage of the chaos to get up to all sorts of vile things, so I dealt with them."

"Unorthodox faction? Did you just say unorthodox faction?"

"Yes. They were committing atrocities and making them look like Dark Heaven's work. I went after them and smashed about six of their sects. The rest of the small fry scattered."

"…!"

I listened with my mouth open. At last, the pieces fell into place.

That Murim practitioner who fled Guangxi.

The man who had supposedly caught an endemic disease and died as soon as he entered Nanman had actually been unorthodox faction small fry fleeing Jeok Cheongang's fiery fists.

Crayfish side with crabs, and people know how to read the room.

Nanman already shunned outsiders. There was no way those people could admit that they were bad guys, and in the process, the unorthodox practitioners killed by Jeok Cheongang had been transformed into righteous heroes who loved justice and peace.

A story like that could take hold because Nanman was so isolated from the outside world.

How the fuck did that happen?

I stared at Jeok Cheongang. Then another thought struck me, and I spoke up quickly.

"Then on your way here, did you happen to—"

"I don't know who you're asking about, but I met them all. The river bandits diving around in the Yangtze. The Nanman people who greeted me with spears and swords. Even your subordinates."

"Oh."

"The Escort King's granddaughter told me you were in danger the moment she saw me. That Hyuk fellow grabbed my trouser leg and sobbed so hard I nearly broke his wrist."

I could picture them from his words alone—how desperate they must have been.

And I could picture Jeok Cheongang racing here the moment he heard I was in danger, without a question or a moment's hesitation.

"But why are we talking about them? I'm the one owed an explanation."

He made a show of scowling. I found myself laughing.

"…You're laughing?"

The disbelief on his face only made me smile wider.

"Of course I am. We're both alive, and we've found each other again."

"…!"

"I'm sorry. And thank you. I know you have a lot of questions. I'll explain everything later. I promise."

Jeok Cheongang looked as though he had plenty to say, but when he answered, his voice was subdued.

"You damn brat."

There was so much in those three words. For a moment, it almost sounded as though he were thanking me for staying alive. Between us, that was enough.

"Stop smiling. I'll get attached."

"For someone who supposedly isn't attached, you were crying pretty bitterly. Of course, I'm not talking about you, Old Master."

"…Shut that mouth of yours."

He must have remembered what he had been doing a moment ago. Still huffing, he took my hand and pulled me to my feet.

Pat, pat.

The dust and stone grit covering my entire body fell away. The pain had been gone for a long time, but my vision blurred for a moment.

Hmm.

I held back a groan. Five level-ups had healed my body, and it moved exactly as I wanted. My mind was another matter. Battle after battle without a moment's rest had left me exhausted.

Ah, I want to sleep.

I wanted to collapse where I stood. To sleep until my body and mind felt refreshed, then wake to a clear sky and spend the day slowly shaking off the drowsiness.

But… not yet.

Dark clouds still filled the sky. All around us, people lay groaning, some lightly wounded, others gravely hurt.

If we left them there, they would fall asleep and never wake again.

Jeok Cheongang finally looked around. His expression darkened.

"…I should have been faster."

It was pointless regret and needless self-reproach. If Jeok Cheongang hadn't come, all of us—including me—might have been buried here.

"Let's hurry. Before it gets any later."

I nodded and chose the quickest, most accurate way to find the survivors.

Activate Skill: Qi Sense.

Ding.

Along with the clear ringing of a bell announcing that the System had activated, a blue circle spread outward from me and enclosed a set area. At the same time, Level display windows rose here and there, and my chest tightened.

Too few.

I could see only about thirty Level display windows.

That meant the Nanman warriors, once nearly a thousand strong, and the three hundred members of the Baekcheon Unit had fallen here.

There was one small mercy: those still breathing did not seem to be in critical condition.

By the end, even the Southern Heaven Demon Empress must have been conserving every scrap of strength.

The thought weighed on me as I rushed to the nearest fallen man.

Wang Ho, Commander of the Baekcheon Unit.

I grasped the wrist of the man who had charged at the Southern Heaven Demon Empress until the final moment, then sent internal energy through his back and along his spine with my other hand.

Ssshhhhhh.

"C-cough."

Wang Ho spat out a mouthful of dark blood. Color began to return to his pale face.

He had been struck particularly hard because he had fought the fiercest battle among the Baekcheon Unit, but this should let us breathe a little easier.

Others were plainly in far worse shape.

Hhh… hhh…

A thin breath escaped through the nose of a giant who had collapsed on his knees. Jeok Cheongang recognized him and let out a low groan.

"…He took a hell of a hit. He wasn't wounded this badly even during the Great Faction War."

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress's One Strike, launched at the cost of her own life, had been that devastating.

Countless sword fragments and pieces of debris were lodged deep throughout his body. The Beast Miao King had also suffered massive internal injuries while protecting me, leaving him unconscious. The sight of him was awful.

"Old Master, do you think—"

Jeok Cheongang heard the worry in my voice and shook his head before I could finish.

"The Beast Miao King is as tough as iron, so don't worry. If this old man does his best, he should be able to survive. But…"

His words trailed off. The certainty in his voice faded as he looked toward the enormous White Tiger lying a few steps away.

"I don't know about that beast. It seems extraordinary, even for an animal, but must it be saved?"

Yes. No matter what it takes.

Before I could say it aloud, a quiet thought reached us.

—If that is how it ends, then that too is my fate.

"…!"

—You have lived a long time, old human. Your face is different from the one I saw in the imugi's[3014] memories, but what you are has not changed.

Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened. The guardian spirit turned its gaze from him to me.

—Come closer.

I bit my lip and went to it. I sat beside its head and stroked the back of its neck, soaked with blood. A low growl escaped it.

—How insolent. How dare you lay a hand on this body?

What could I say?

As I silently stroked only its neck, the guardian spirit sent another thought to me.

—Though I cannot say I dislike it. There was an impudent human much like you, long ago.

I thought I knew who it meant.

[3014] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being associated with dragons.

The first Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace. The only human the guardian spirit had ever opened its heart to in all its long life.

—Strange, isn't it? Everything about you is different, yet you remind me of him. He returned to the earth hundreds of years ago.

"…!"

—Perhaps that is why I saved you without thinking. Why I entrusted the sacred stone to a mere human.

The White Tiger's enormous body heaved beneath my hand. Breathing raggedly, the guardian spirit lifted its blue-white eyes to mine.

At that moment, I understood instinctively.

Why it needed the sacred stone. What it meant to do with it.

The rift.

The guardian spirit was trying to close that dense darkness—the rift—all by itself.

Just as an imugi[3015] had done several months ago.

[3015] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being associated with dragons.

Chapter 712

I hoped I was wrong.

I wanted the thought that had just occurred to me—my suspicion—to be completely unfounded.

But the guardian spirit's thoughts reached me the next moment, and I knew it was true.

—Someone has to do it. Perhaps this is the fate I was given.

Just as I had understood what the guardian spirit intended, it had understood me.

My face was reflected in its clear blue-white eyes. They seemed to see through everything.

—Until that darkness… that thing you call a rift is gone, this will not end. No, it will be the beginning of another catastrophe.

I couldn't deny it. After a desperate struggle, we had defeated the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and her subordinates. But the rift they had opened remained, consuming the space around it.

Even now.

Ssshhhhhh.

The darkness had already passed beyond the Inner Palace and was advancing toward the Outer Palace.

The demonic qi within it would corrupt living things, transform them into beings that had lost their reason, and bring about another disaster.

Basically, an army of monsters.

The rift reminded me of a Gate, but I had no way of knowing how far its power would reach.

If the demonic qi flowing from it could swallow Nanman—or more—then the darkness would keep spreading.

Beyond Nanman, until it consumed all under heaven.

—Human. You have likely guessed that only the sacred stone's power can withstand that darkness. Someone must enter the center of the rift with the stone and endure it.

I knew that, too. Only a few months ago, the Water God Dragon had sacrificed itself to seal the rift.

And I knew the price it had paid.

"What if you become something different from what you've been until now?"

I couldn't bring myself to say *a mutant*. The guardian spirit gave me a faint smile.

—Kill me. Without the slightest hesitation.

"…!"

—With your strength and that old human's, it shouldn't be too difficult, even if I become a corrupted being.

I stared at the guardian spirit, then forced myself to speak. I had been holding on to this thought since the moment I understood its intentions. After turning it over for so long, I finally asked.

"What if I seal the rift myself?"

The answer came from someone else.

"Don't be ridiculous!"

It was Jeok Cheongang's shout. He had been tending to the Beast Miao King's Internal Injury.

"Out of the question. Say whatever you like. This old man will not allow it."

"But, Old Master—"

"I don't want to hear it. I don't care how much you've accomplished. We have no idea what might happen in there. How could I let you go?"

"I'll come back safe and sound without so much as a hair out of place. I promise."

"Without so much as a hair out of place?"

"Yes."

I nodded. Jeok Cheongang watched me in silence, then spoke.

"If that's what you want, fine."

"Then—"

"You stay here. This old man will go."

"…!"

"If you can return without a scratch, then it would be even more certain if I went instead. Am I wrong?"

That hit the heart of it. I had no answer.

The guardian spirit's thoughts rang out.

—Old human. If the darkness changes that young human into something else, what will you do?

"I'll kill the boy. So he can find peace."

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation. His voice dropped.

"And then this old man will choose death as well."

—Young human. What would you do if it were the other way around?

I said nothing. The guardian spirit understood my silence and smiled.

—Yes. That is why I must go.

"…"

—The humans of this land have already shed enough blood. There is no reason for you and that old human to sacrifice yourselves in my place. You still have many fates ahead of you, while I have already passed through many fates.

The guardian spirit raised its blue-white eyes to Jeok Cheongang.

—Even if the situation becomes irreversible, do not hesitate to kill me.

Jeok Cheongang gave a small nod.

“I’ll give it everything I have.”

—Thank you.

Grrr. The guardian spirit drew a labored breath and opened its mouth toward me.

—Jin Taekyung. It is time.

What more could I say?

I slipped a hand inside my robes and murmured inwardly.

Inventory open. Summon.

The next moment, something giving off a faint, warm light rested on my palm. I held it out to the guardian spirit.

Jeok Cheongang felt its mysterious energy and murmured, almost groaning.

“Could that be…?”

—This sacred stone, which you humans call the Beast King Stone, was the one mission I had left. The reason I existed. And now we will be together until the end.

Ssshhhh.

The sacred stone rose slowly into the air and was drawn into the guardian spirit’s mouth.

Warmth spread outward with its faint radiance.

At the same time, the guardian spirit’s ragged breathing steadied. Strength began to return to its fallen body.

Rustle. Thud.

At last, the enormous White Tiger rose and set a blood-soaked forepaw on the ground.

Thud. Thud.

One step. Then another.

Each step was heavier than ever, yet nothing could stop it.

Not even the darkness, now incomparably denser and stickier than at first, could stop them.

Kraaaash!

Pools of blood lay everywhere, with countless corpses scattered among them. The darkness surged over them like a wave, only to strike the light surrounding the guardian spirit and fall back.

If the darkness flowing from the rift corrupted everything, then the light contained within the sacred stone possessed the power of purification.

—Kraaaaang!

A fierce roar shook heaven and earth. Its silver mane, stained red, whipped violently in the wind.

Before I knew it, the guardian spirit had become a gust of wind and was racing forward.

Shweeeek!

I watched its back as it shot through the darkness.

I watched that faint but unmistakable streak of light cross countless corpses and piles of rubble.

I watched it race across the vast expanse until it reached the cliff swallowed by pitch-black darkness.

And then I realized something.

At the very end, the guardian spirit had called me by name for the first time.

The guardian spirit was out of breath. Its blood-drenched body felt heavy, and the darkness all around constricted it from head to toe.

Imugi. Did you feel this way, too?

With that unheard question, the guardian spirit took a step with all its strength into the gaping fissure in the cliff.

It had to keep going, however hard it was.

It had not known before. Now it did.

This had been its one mission from the beginning. The guardian spirit was meant to protect not the sacred stone, but everything in this land.

Crunch.

Its paw sank deep into the ground beneath the weight of its next step. The closer it came to the center of the rift, the harder the darkness and demonic qi pressed down on its body.

As its consciousness dimmed, memories of the distant past flashed before its blue-white eyes.

Come to think of it, I was always alone.

It had no father, mother, or siblings.

No. At first, it had not even known such things existed.

To one small, pure-white White Tiger, this space it had seen from the moment it first opened its eyes was the world itself. And it had a friend who had always been there with it.

A friend it could neither play with nor speak to, but who had never left its side.

Tap.

Something touched its soft white forepaw, which was like a ball of cotton.

It was a stone so clear that *crystal* would have been a better name for it. As always, it was warm and comforting.

Grrr.

The young White Tiger let out a contented growl and soon fell asleep, breathing softly.

And at the feet of the sleeping White Tiger, on a hill drenched in warm light that was neither sunlight nor moonlight, a green sprout suddenly pushed its head above the ground.

Rustle. Tap.

The sprout, no larger than a fingernail, began to straighten its bent stem. Colorful buds appeared, and branches grew.

Before long, a giant tree stood where the sprout had been, its roots sunk deep into the earth. Leaves hung from its countless branches, casting a broad, cool shade.

Ssshhhh.

A wind blew from somewhere, stirring the tree's full crown.

A leaf that had clung stubbornly to its branch finally broke free and fell into the shade.

At the soft tap of its landing, the creature napping beneath the tree opened its eyes.

—Grrr.

It rose with a low growl.

It was a White Tiger.

Far too enormous and powerful to be called a cub—or even an ordinary tiger—it looked around with blue-white eyes.

No one knew exactly how much time had passed.

Only that it had been a long time. The place where it had been born and raised was always peaceful, and it was always day.

But things had changed.

Change as certain as the sprout growing into a giant tree, or the small, soft White Tiger cub becoming a huge and powerful being.

Yes. Him.

It had first met him three hundred years ago. He was a tribal chieftain who led humans and possessed a mysterious power that drew beasts to him. For someone built like a bear, he smiled an awful lot.

That power was probably why the beasts of the Sacred Land had accepted him without the guardian spirit's permission.

"Oh. I've never seen a White Tiger this big before. What's your name?"

At first, the guardian spirit had been surprised that a human had entered the Sacred Land without its permission. Then the human bastard had stroked the back of its neck without a trace of fear, leaving it dumbfounded.

So it asked him a question.

“And what is *your* name?”

It could still picture the insolent human bastard’s face. He had gaped at the guardian spirit, then answered in a dazed voice.

“Yayul Cheon…”

“I do not know how you entered this place, but if I see you here again, I will tear you limb from limb and kill you. Do you understand?”

The next day, the guardian spirit realized something.

That young human bastard named Yayul Cheon had less fear than any living creature it had ever seen.

“I believe I told you not to let yourself be seen.”

“That’s why I hid.”

“…Are you joking with me right now?”

“You found me by smell. You didn’t *see* me. I’m lying facedown in the grass.”

“No, is that supposed to be an answer? …Wait. What is that smell?”

“Grilled meat. I brought some in case you were hungry. Want some?”

“Meat? Did you hunt the beasts?”

“…”

The guardian spirit could not say how they had grown close. Like getting soaked in a light rain without noticing, they came to know each other little by little. The years passed quickly.

Ten years. Twenty years. And then, the day they last faced each other.

“It’s been a long time.”

Yayul Cheon had not visited for several years. He was no longer a young man.

His once-black hair was half gray, and his eyes were worn with fatigue.

“I need your help. Only with your power and the sacred stone’s can we win this war and restore peace to Nanman.”

The guardian spirit knew what kind of war he was fighting. It knew how evil their enemies were.

But it refused.

The sacred stone—and the guardian spirit itself—were merely observers. That was what it believed then.

At least, it had believed it then.

And regret always came too late.

If I had helped you then, would the fate of this land have changed?

The guardian spirit’s blue-white eyes cleared as it came back from its memories.

Turbulent darkness churned before it, writhing strangely and spewing demonic qi as though it would swallow everything.

Ssssss!

Within the warped space, the guardian spirit struggled through one final step and stared into the center of the rift.

Then it hurled its faintly glowing body forward with all the strength it had left.

—Kraaaaang!

A single roar rang out, and an enormous wave of force burst outward.

Chapter 713

The wait was short.

I had gathered the survivors in one place, and with Jeok Cheongang's help, the Beast Miao King had just managed to open his eyes.

Crack. Crack-crack.

The change began.

I felt it. So did Jeok Cheongang. Even the Baekcheon Unit warriors, still far from recovered, and the Beast Miao King, who had only just regained consciousness, felt the tremor.

Whoooosh.

Space twisted. The darkness that had writhed as though it were alive went still, and the wind began to flow in one direction.

Toward the gap in the cliff, its enormous jaws open like some primordial beast, beyond the thick darkness that had swallowed the guardian spirit.

At the same time, I could clearly see and hear it.

—Kraaaaang!

A roar echoed outward, and a single streak of light grew brighter within the darkness.

This is…

I stared at it in disbelief. So did everyone else.

The injured survivors forgot even to groan. The Beast Miao King, barely conscious, reached toward the distant light with a dazed look on his face.

It carried qi warmer than sunlight and as clear as water.

Silence fell, as though the world had stopped. Then Jeok Cheongang's low voice reached my ears.

"It's coming."

"…!"

With those words, time began to move again.

Rumble. Boom!

An enormous explosion.

Everything drew together, then burst outward at once. A deafening roar filled my ears as an invisible shock wave swept toward us, broad as a road.

I heard Jeok Cheongang shout through the gale.

"Watch out—!"

Kuwaaaang!

The wind—no, the storm—swallowed his voice.

A distant flash of darkness and light mixed together, blocking my vision, while the enormous shock wave battered and flung away everything within its range.

But—

Now.

I brought White Flame down in a diagonal slash.

Hellfire surged along its transparent spearhead and burned through the wind. The flames found their way into the invisible grain of the shock wave and struck it.

No. They canceled it out.

Kuwaaaang! Crack!

The earth shook with a deafening roar. The impact was powerful enough to push back both of my firmly rooted legs.

Jeok Cheongang had stepped forward to protect the survivors too. He flicked both sleeves.

Fwoosh. Boom!

The Blazing Flame Divine Palm, brought to perfection.

Unlike mine, his two fully formed fire dragons rampaged through the air, tearing into the storm. Flames rose across a radius of dozens of jang[3016], consuming the wind and reducing to ash the countless fragments of debris hurled at us like hidden weapons.

Ssszzzzzt!

Smoke and steam filled every direction. In a world dyed entirely pale white, I exhaled the breath I had been holding and reached out.

Boom!

Compressed air burst outward, driving the smoke and steam away.

And beyond the vision that slowly cleared, the darkness was dispersing, while a collapse that had only just begun awaited us all.

Rumble. Rumble-rumble!

The cliff was coming down. All two hundred jang[3017] of it.

Jagged rocks, great and small, poured from above and filled the sky. It was a terrifying sight, but sunlight had begun to break through above them.

That could mean only one thing.

The rift… closed.

It was over.

The long, fierce battle had finally ended. We had stopped a catastrophe that might have claimed hundreds of thousands of lives. Perhaps millions.

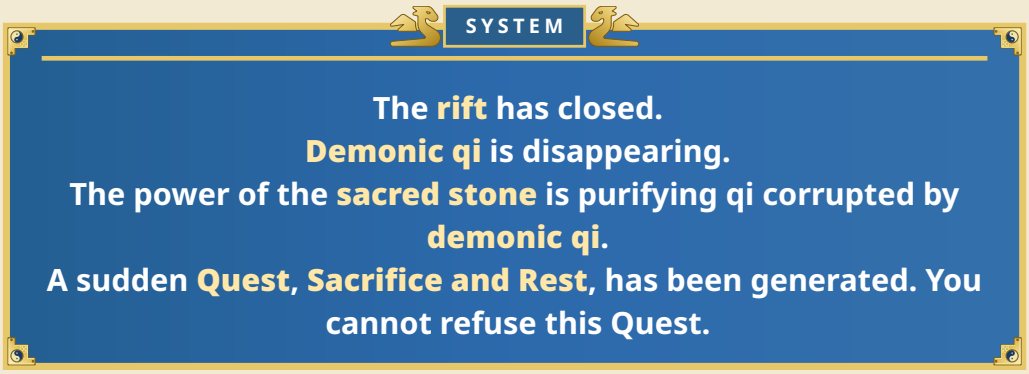
Why was the emptiness greater than the joy?

Perhaps because I knew better than anyone that something remained unfinished.

[3016] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

[3017] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

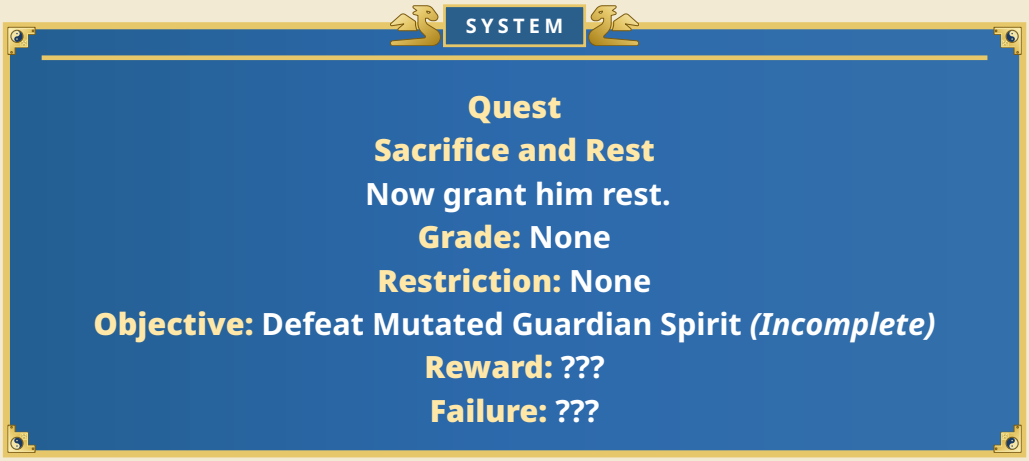
Ding.



As the System notification reached my ears, I suddenly reached out.

The darkness that had writhed painfully in the air like a living creature scattered between my fingers.

The sunlight shining through the slowly dispersing storm clouds was warm. Floating above it was a translucent holographic window displaying only a few short lines.



This was a first.

Never had a Quest description been so short. Nor had its restriction, which usually bore the three characters of my name, been open to anyone at all.

Perhaps even the System knew what he had sacrificed.

A being worthy of the name *divine beast* had given himself up and become a corrupted guardian spirit.

Step.

I walked through the darkness as it broke apart and blew away with the ash. Jeok Cheongang followed quietly. Among the countless rocks still crashing down, I sensed someone's presence.

I saw it.

SYSTEM

Lv. 155 Mutated Guardian Spirit

The fur that had shone silver even in darkness was black now. So were the blue-white eyes that had once been as clear as the pond in the Sacred Land.

Fangs twice their former length gleamed at us.

—Grrrrr.

A low, savage growl. Then he moved like a flash of light.

Whoosh!

His form blurred, and the ten-odd jang[3018] between us vanished. His blood-soaked forepaw struck the ground, launching his enormous body into the air.

Pop.

A shadow fell over our heads. Jeok Cheongang and I struck with all our strength, remembering what the guardian spirit had asked of us before he left.

Kill me. Without the slightest hesitation.

We kept our promise.

Whoosh. Slash!

It was somewhere deep and cold. No light reached it. Not even the faintest warmth.

He lay curled up there, sensing death approaching—or perhaps it had already come.

Then he felt warmth and opened his eyes.

No. It was not warmth. It was heat.

Through his blurred vision, he made out a familiar face.

“Jin Tae… kyung.”

His voice came out cracked.

The young man watching Baeksang open his eyes answered evenly.

“Yes.”

That one word told Baeksang it was all over. Or perhaps it was the sunlight falling over Jin Taekyung’s shoulder.

So this is how it ended.

Baeksang looked up at the blue sky, clear of storm clouds.

How strange. He had lost everything he had wanted, yet he felt no despair. Only emptiness.

[3018] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

“What happened to the Southern Heaven Demon Empress?”

“She’s dead.”

“The rift must have disappeared as well.”

“…Yes.”

There was a hesitation in Jin Taekyung’s voice. He turned his head, his gaze resting briefly on the enormous tiger lying nearby.

But Baeksang saw the countless bodies of beasts and humans scattered all around them.

“Let me ask you one thing,” Jin Taekyung said, his voice low. “Did you know from the beginning that it would come to this?”

Baeksang stared at the bodies with empty eyes.

“Yes. I knew.”

“…!”

Jin Taekyung clenched his teeth and glared at Baeksang. Baeksang did not avoid the gaze, where flames seemed to pour down in streams.

“To be precise, I learned a few months ago, when a letter arrived from the Central Plains.”

It had come from Henan. Along with an invitation to join the soon-to-be-established Murim Alliance, it contained a detailed account of the events in Hubei.

“That was when I understood why Dark Heaven had reached into Nanman, in the Outer Lands, instead of the Central Plains. I understood what the Southern Heaven Demon Empress meant by her grand plan.”

“And knowing that, you still…”

“Followed orders. I was already a monster, not a man.”

People said ten years could change the mountains and rivers. Sometimes an earthquake brought a mountain down, or a flood forced a river into a new course.

Baeksang had spent more than forty years amid earthquakes and floods of his own, losing his heart little by little. He had lost his only child, and he wanted revenge on the people of the Central Plains who had caused that loss.

But there was more to it.

“After the Great Faction War, I hated the Demonic Path more than anyone. If the Central Plains saw me as a turncoat they could never forgive, then those bastards were enemies I had to kill.”

Jin Taekyung gave a hollow laugh.

Dark Heaven and the Demonic Cult were branches of the same tree, growing from one root. If Baeksang hated the Demonic Path, how could he have joined forces with the Dark Heaven that had killed his child?

Yet he had joined hands with the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and brought about this catastrophe. He had let Dark Heaven open the rift. Knowing how many

would die, he had still ordered a general mobilization and brought nearly ten thousand warriors and beasts into the Inner Palace.

To offer them up as living sacrifices.

“You stupid fuck. How can you even say—”

For some reason, Jin Taekyung’s words suddenly trailed off.

Baeksang moved his bloodstained lips.

“Yes. There was something more important to me than hatred. More important than anything.”

At that moment, someone’s face flashed through Jin Taekyung’s mind. He understood why the eyes above that mask had seemed so familiar.

“…Baekhwi.”

It was not Jin Taekyung who had spoken.

Baeksang raised his unfocused eyes toward a figure approaching from the distance. A huge man stumbled closer. Despite Jeok Cheongang’s attempts to stop him, the Beast Miao King came to stand before Baeksang.

“That child,” he asked, the words almost a groan. “Was he alive?”

Baeksang nodded weakly.

That was answer enough. The Beast Miao King knew what the child meant to Baeksang. He knew what his sworn younger brother would do for his only child.

It made him grieve—and it made him furious.

“Why? Why didn’t you tell me? Why?”

“I didn’t want the Palace Lord… I didn’t want you to die, hyung[3019].”

“…!”

“And Hwi… that child. I would have lost him all over again.”

Old memories passed through Baeksang’s eyes.

The day he first faced the darkness, he had rejected the Southern Heaven Demon Empress’s offer outright. Then she told him that the child he believed the Great Snow Fiend had killed was alive.

“I accepted her offer. I believed her promise that she would let Hwi live once the grand plan was complete.”

He had believed her. No—he had been forced to push down his distrust. It was the only way he could see his child again.

Whenever his resolve wavered after that, he went to the Southern Heaven Demon Empress to look upon his child’s face. Dark Heaven’s sorcerers had kept Hwi alive, sunk in a deep sleep.

“But I knew what I was doing. I knew how many people my choice would kill.”

That was why he had created the Baekcheon Unit.

[3019] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close bond.

Not for himself, but for someone else—for the hope that he would stop this catastrophe.

"I couldn't do that myself."

A child might kill a parent, but no parent could kill their child.

Baeksang was a father. Even if he went back to that moment dozens of times—hundreds—he would make the same choice.

Cough.

Baeksang spat up blood and lifted his blurred eyes toward the Beast Miao King.

A memory passed through them: the saddest and happiest day of his life.

Yes. That day.

Baeksang had wept on the day he lost his beloved wife and gained the child he would come to love more than anyone. He had sat across from his only sworn elder brother and drunk fruit wine as though it were his last day alive.

Just as he had decades later, on the day the Southern Heaven Demon Empress came to him.

"I have one last request."

Baeksang gave a faint smile.

"Please kill me, hyung[3020]."

[3020] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he has a close bond.

Chapter 714

"Please kill me, hyung[3021]."

The moment he heard those words, the Beast Miao King closed his eyes without realizing it.

His chest ached. He could barely breathe. The request his only sworn younger brother had made after so many years cut deep, like a sharp blade.

Hyung[3022]. He called me hyung[3023].

He had wanted to hear that word for so long. Now he wanted to cover his ears.

He would rather be a fool who had seen and heard none of this. Even an incompetent Palace Lord, if it meant he could escape this moment.

If only he could.

"This brings back old memories."

The Beast Miao King opened his eyes at the quiet voice. Baeksang's face, wearing a faint smile, was reflected in his eyes.

"We were young back then. I wanted to become Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace someday, and I was desperate to beat you."

"…Yes. You were."

They had been little more than boys.

Baeksang had seen the Beast Miao King, several years his senior, as a rival. To the Beast Miao King, Baeksang had simply been adorable. Born an only child, he had never had a sibling.

"But I never caught up to you. Whenever I thought I was getting close, you were already far ahead again."

"That was because you were younger than me. If we had been the same age…"

"It wouldn't have changed anything. We were born with different potential."

But Baeksang had not given up. Every day, he challenged the Beast Miao King to a duel. Every day, he lost. And the next day, he came back as though nothing had happened.

"Then one day, I realized that idiot who stood two heads taller than me wasn't so bad after all."

Baeksang could still picture the big boy pulling him to his feet and brushing the dust from his clothes after a fall.

[3021] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or a close older male.

[3022] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or a close older male.

[3023] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or a close older male.

And the shadow of someone quietly leaving medicinal herbs outside his quarters whenever he was sick.

“So I challenged you to one last duel.”

The result was no different that day.

Baeksang fought harder than he ever had—and lost.

If that had been the end of it, the day would have been like any other. But this time, he did not push away the hand that helped him up. He did not stalk back to his quarters, huffing in anger.

Instead, he produced two bottles of fruit wine he had stolen from somewhere and muttered as though to himself.

“I’ve got wine, but no one to drink it with. Come along if you want.”

At the Beast Miao King’s quiet voice, Baeksang’s eyes widened for a moment. Then he coughed up blood and laughed.

“Cough. You still remember that?”

“How could I forget? You’re the only twelve-year-old brat I’ve ever known who’d say something so cheeky.”

“Then you must remember how I emptied both bottles myself.”

“Both bottles?”

The Beast Miao King could not help laughing. Moisture had gathered at the corners of his crescent-shaped eyes.

“Well, I vividly remember the little brat who collapsed before he had even finished a single cup. I also remember what you said while looking at me with those unfocused eyes.”

Baeksang nodded weakly, his unfocused gaze reaching back into the past.

“I said I’d be content to become Great Chieftain, so you should become a great Palace Lord. I couldn’t have said that to you sober. That’s why I drank.”

“And what you said after that? Did you need to be drunk for that too?”

“Of course not.”

Baeksang continued in a quiet voice.

“You were… simply my hyung[3024]. Perhaps you had been since the day we met.”

The two boys had tasted alcohol for the first time, then collapsed and fallen asleep. When they opened their eyes the next morning in an old shrine, they had become sworn brothers closer than anyone else.

In the mountains. In the fields. By rivers and in marshes.

They were together on the battlefield too.

Until a terrible fate tore them apart.

[3024] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or a close older male.

"Hyung[3025]."

"…"

"The day we became sworn brothers, you made me a vow. You said you'd become a better Palace Lord than anyone. That you'd put Nanman above all else and fight for the people of this land."

"Enough. Stop."

The Beast Miao King already knew why Baeksang had brought up these memories. He knew what Baeksang meant to say.

"Do I truly have to… kill you with my own hands?"

Baeksang gave a small nod.

"Far too much blood has already been spilled. Everything happened because of my misguided choices."

The traitor who had betrayed Nanman and its countless tribespeople had to be executed. That was a duty the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace had to carry out himself—the only way to keep the vow he had made in the old shrine.

"You vowed to become a better Palace Lord than anyone."

With effort, Baeksang raised a hand and pointed behind the Beast Miao King, who stood as rigid as a statue.

His trembling finger indicated the countless tribespeople and warriors making their way over the rubble into the Inner Palace.

"Everyone is watching. You and me. All of us."

It was true.

The people constantly pouring into the Inner Palace had learned that the catastrophe was over and cheered. Then they were horrified by the sight that unfolded before their eyes. Finally, they fell silent at the sight of their returning Palace Lord and the traitor collapsed before him.

No. Not silent.

Furious.

"I can feel their anger. It's aimed at me."

This was the moment Baeksang had feared most—and wanted more than anything.

If this moment had come, someone had stopped him. Dark Heaven and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's grand plan had failed.

That was why he could laugh aloud. Why he could haul his dying body upright, wring out the last of his strength, and shout.

"Remember this!"

[3025] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or a close older male.

His eyes were dim, as though their light might go out at any moment. But his voice rang through the Inner Palace, clear enough for everyone to hear.

“Though the grand plan has failed, the day will surely come when Dark Heaven’s sky devours Nanman!”

“…!”

The cry carried over heaps of rubble and corpses to reach every ear.

Blood burst between Baeksang’s teeth with each syllable. Strength drained from his body. Still, he did not stop. He could not.

He was the traitor who had betrayed them all and brought about this catastrophe.

A man guilty of an unforgivable crime had to die a criminal, without sympathy or an explanation for what he had done.

That was… the last thing Baeksang could do.

“That day, which will come before long…!”

He swallowed the blood rising in his throat, clenched his teeth, and shouted on.

“Those contemptible Han Chinese bastards of the Central Plains, and you utterly primitive people of Nanman, will all kneel and submit at the feet of the great Lord of Heaven!”

Baeksang’s bloodstained lips spread into a bright smile.

At that moment, no one was a more loyal servant of the Lord of Heaven, a more faithful dog of Dark Heaven.

And his sworn elder brother had only one choice.

Crack!

A fist shot through the air, crushing flesh and shattering bone.

The single punch buried deep in Baeksang’s chest carried green Force, like the broad fields where they had rolled around together as children.

Thank you, hyung[3026]*.*

You became a truly great Palace Lord, just as you promised.

Along with a murmur no one could hear, Baeksang stared at the face of one person visible beyond his fading field of vision.

But why…?

Why are you crying?

The great Palace Lord who had executed a traitor and stopped a catastrophe was weeping bitterly, like a child who had lost something precious.

Then he shouted, almost howling.

“I have executed Baeksang, the traitor who joined forces with Dark Heaven!”

The people’s cheers reached Baeksang faintly. His head fell back, and he looked up at the sky.

[3026] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a younger man for an older brother or a close older male.

Clear and blue.

The world was no longer dark.

Isn't that right, Hwi?

He thought of the son who had lost his reason and driven a sword into his father's chest, and of the child already waiting for him in another world, smiling brightly.

Baeksang smiled in peace.

Thud.

His strength left him, and his body collapsed.

The world remained bright. The people went on cheering.

And in place of his sworn elder brother, who was not even allowed to wail, someone closed Baeksang's eyes.

"…Fuck. What the hell are you smiling about? It's not like you did anything right."

Jin Taekyung muttered to himself, then suddenly looked down at the old thing clenched in his hand.

He didn't know. Baeksang deserved to die. He was a bad man who had done terrible things. So why did Jin feel so damn awful? Why had he brought this?

Damn it.

Along with the curses that never left his mouth, Jin Taekyung covered Baeksang's face with the object in his hand.

Baekcheon.

The old silk, bearing someone's years and hopes, fluttered in a cool breeze from somewhere.

Through the endless cheers came voices, faint as echoes.

"Captain!"

"Pavilion Master—no, Young Master Jin!"

"Taishan is here! Taishan is sorry he's late!"

"Hey, you bastard! Are you alive?"

Am I hearing things?

Jin Taekyung turned. He stared blankly at the familiar faces drawing closer, then finally let out a quiet laugh.

And collapsed.

I had a very long dream.

A terrible nightmare.

Even in my sleep, I was fighting for my life. In the modern world, I fought monsters. In Murim, I fought Dark Heaven.

Then, after I defeated the Southern Heaven Demon Empress in a brutal fight—just as I had in real life—some masked bastard appeared and said:

"You defeated the Western Heaven Demon Lord and even the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. Not bad."

I was wondering what hole this bastard had crawled out of when he went on.

"But the Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress were merely the weakest of our Eight Great Heavenly Kings."

"…?"

"I am the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who commands the east. Directly beneath me in rank is the East-West Heaven Demon Empress, who commands the east and west."

No, fuck this. Four directions were plenty. What the hell is an East-West Heaven Demon Empress?

He'd taken the bit so far I had nothing to say.

At this rate, I feared that even if I returned to the modern world, I might find the Dongducheon Demon Lord or the Incheon Demon Empress waiting for me.

But what else could I do? I didn't know I was dreaming, so I fought like hell.

With every step I took toward him, people I had killed—or failed to save—appeared and blocked my path.

"Just a little more. Just a little farther…"

"If you'd moved faster, we could have lived."

"We could have gone home to our families."

"Why do you get to live when we had to die?"

"Why? Why? Why?"

I had no answer. I stopped moving, and they sank their teeth into my torso.

Slowly. Relentlessly.

I could only stand there, frozen like a statue, because I recognized a face among the mutants.

"I cared for you more than anyone, but in the end, you couldn't save me."

A face that couldn't be among them. That mustn't be.

Jeok Cheongang.

He came toward me with both arms gone and a gaping hole in the middle of his chest. Then he sank his teeth into the back of my neck.

As he greedily swallowed flesh and blood, he whispered in my ear.

"But when is this infuriating bastard supposed to wake up?"

And at that moment, my eyes flew open.

"…!"

A strong, unfamiliar smell hung in the air. Above me was a ceiling I didn't recognize.

I blinked blankly, slowly becoming aware of reality. Then a familiar voice pierced my ears.

“Come clean now, and I’ll let you off with a little singeing. You’re a quack, aren’t you?”

“N-no, sir.”

“The child hasn’t woken up for seven days and nights. Does that make any sense? Go get the Beast Miao King.”

“Gasp. Th-that’s…”

“I said bring Yayul Cheok here!”

I turned toward the booming voice. Jeok Cheongang had a physician by the collar and was shaking him violently.

Chapter 715

The room smelled of medicinal herbs. A middle-aged man stood trembling with a long acupuncture needle in his hand while Jeok Cheongang held him by the collar.

I can see where this is going. Oh, I can see it.

I had only just woken up, but the situation was easy enough to grasp. The man, who looked like a physician, spotted me blinking over Jeok Cheongang's shoulder and shouted.

"Ah! Ahhh! He's awake! He's awake!"

"…"

Even my mother wouldn't have been that happy to see me wake up.

I guarantee it. That wasn't the joy of a physician whose patient had recovered. It was the relief of a victim spotting the police while facing a serial killer.

Jeok Cheongang let go of the physician's collar without a fuss and turned to look at me.

He said nothing, even after the physician hurried out. For a long while, he just looked at me.

Then he spoke.

"You took your time waking up."

At his gruff tone, I shrugged.

I couldn't exactly tell him I'd had a fucking nightmare in which Old Master tore into my neck with his teeth.

Did you sleep well?

More or less.

"How do you feel?"

"Light. My head's clear, too."

That was no exaggeration. My body felt as light as a feather, and the long sleep had cleared the fatigue from my head. I felt sharper than ever.

They said I was unconscious for seven days and nights, didn't they?

I must have been more exhausted than I realized.

Not to brag, but it was rare for a master who had reached the Supreme Peak realm like me to remain unconscious for an entire week.

Then, without meaning to, I blurted out, "That's a relief."

"What is?"

"That this isn't a dream."

"…"

"It really is a relief."

I looked around, overcome with emotion.

Sunlight slipped through the half-open window, and birdsong tickled my ears. Far off, I could sense people passing by and talking quietly among themselves.

I'm alive.

It was ironic.

I was breathing. I could feel the world around me. Yet I still found it hard to believe I was alive.

At the same time, a hollow emptiness took hold of me.

For an instant, the darkness that had wrapped around the Inner Palace seemed to pass over the sunlight settling on the window. So did the sight of countless corpses collapsed with their faces buried in pools of blood.

So… none of it was a dream.

The joy and relief of surviving faded, leaving guilt and bitterness in their place.

I stared blankly at the window until a low voice reached me.

"In the end, some survive, and some die."

Tap.

A hand came to rest on my shoulder. I felt its warmth as Jeok Cheongang gazed into the distance and continued.

"That is the natural order no one can defy. That is Murim."

"…"

"Be grateful you survived, and mourn those who died. For now, that is enough."

Jeok Cheongang walked to the window and threw it open. Sunlight poured in, bathing him in its glow. I watched him in silence.

Thoughts flashed through my mind, and I opened my mouth.

"Old Master."

At my call, Jeok Cheongang smiled warmly and shook his head.

"Enough. You needn't say anything now."

"Ah, that's not what I meant."

"Enough, I said. There's much I want to ask you, but first you need time to gather your thoughts—"

"No, it's just… you're dazzling me."

"Hm?"

I cautiously pointed at his head. Gleaming in the sunlight, his bald scalp was using Solar Fist as a passive Skill.

"Either close the window or move your head a little."

"…!"

"By the way, did you use Force? You shaved it really clean. I get that it's a disguise, but you should've left some hair. What if it doesn't grow back?"

The warm smile vanished from Jeok Cheongang's face.

In an instant, the kindly old man next door became the Blood Monk. He gave me a cold stare.

"You goddamn—"

"I was only asking. Why are you swearing at a patient who just woke up?"

"Would you like to go back to sleep? I could put you out for another three months and fifteen days."

Crack.

Bones shifted in his tightly clenched fist. Sensing I'd made a terrible mistake, I spoke quickly.

"I've slept plenty already."

"This old man thinks you'd like some more."

"I'm really fine. The work here is almost done, so we should hurry back to the Central Plains—"

"That's fine. By the time you wake up, we'll be in Henan at the very least."

I swallowed hard.

"That sounds… really bad."

"Why? The journey will only bore you."

"It won't be boring at all. I like admiring natural scenery."

"How about returning to nature for good?"

"…You're joking, right?"

"Does it sound like a joke?"

"No."

"That part was a joke. Waking up in Henan wasn't."

Whoosh.

Flames curled around Jeok Cheongang's fist. I instinctively looked around, but of course there was no fire extinguisher.

I'm fucked. Shit.

Resigned to my fate, I made a polite request.

"Please go easy on me."

"If you take it without a fuss, I can do that. Which would you prefer, Flame Divine Palm or Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist?"

"…Would either of those not hurt if you used them gently?"

"Would you rather I hit you hard?"

"…Is there anything besides Flame Divine Palm and Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist?"

"There is."

"Oh? What?"

"Dance of the Fire God and Demon."

I asked with complete sincerity.

“Have you actually gone senile?”

Whack!

My vision flashed white.

I writhed with my mouth hanging open, pain shooting through my forehead. Jeok Cheongang’s impossibly gruff voice reached me.

“I thought it was about time you woke up, so I came by for the first time in a while. And here you are, perfectly fine. Stop spouting nonsense and get your strength back. I’m leaving.”

Click.

I opened my eyes just as the door shut firmly behind him. Rubbing my forehead with tears in my eyes, I looked at the space he’d left behind and muttered, “You could’ve stayed a little longer…”

Before my faint voice had faded, a tremor swept through the pavilion.

Boom. Boom. Rumble!

Amazingly, those were someone’s footsteps. Alongside the vibrations of what sounded like a charging elephant, I sensed several others approaching with uncanny lightness.

They were headed toward the firmly closed door Jeok Cheongang had just passed through.

“Hey, wait—!”

But my desperate shout never reached the end.

Crash!

The wooden door burst apart, sending dust billowing into the air.

As I stood there blankly frozen in the quarters that had become a ruin in an instant, I saw several familiar faces through the dust cloud and let out a helpless laugh.

Yeah. Well, this isn’t so bad either.

“How’s everyone been?”

As if on cue, several figures leaped toward me at once.

No—one enormous figure soared nearly to the ceiling and came down on all of us, myself included.

Whoooosh!

“Taishan missed the Pavilion Master!”

“…Ah.”

I hadn’t counted on you.

Bang!

Hearing the crash behind him, Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh.

“Well, what a commotion.”

It had to be that huge fellow—Taishan, or was it Geosan?

The physician who had left the quarters first must already have spread the news. The members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion had rushed over faster than anyone else, barely sparing Jeok Cheongang a glance as they headed toward the pavilion. That had happened only moments ago.

The youngsters want to be together. This old man should give them space.

Granted, there was another old man among them. But Jeok Cheongang had passed ninety-nine long ago. To him, anyone under eighty was in the prime of youth.

It was his firm belief that anyone eighty or younger could chew Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

…Perhaps that’s going a bit far.

After muttering inwardly, Jeok Cheongang began to walk slowly.

He looked up at the sky, which had cleared as though nothing had happened, and watched the Nanman people begin gathering in groups of three or five after hearing the news of Jin Taekyung.

The cool breeze brushed against him, and a thought came to him.

No—a question for someone who wasn’t there to hear it.

Do you really believe that?

After seven days and nights, Jin Taekyung had woken and said he was glad this wasn’t a dream. Truly glad.

But his voice, his eyes, everything Jeok Cheongang had seen told a different story.

He blames himself for surviving. For failing to save them.

No one knew what became of the dead. Jeok Cheongang had, however, seen countless people survive hell. He knew how they went on living with regret and guilt.

The Great Faction War.

He had lived through that seeming eternity of blood and death himself.

But overcoming it makes you stronger.

That was why he had said as little as he could. He had pretended not to notice Jin Taekyung groaning and thrashing in pain while unconscious, then made himself ask:

Did you sleep well?

More or less.

It must have been a terrible nightmare. Jin Taekyung had lied through his teeth without batting an eye.

Cheeky brat.

Jeok Cheongang wasn't angry. He was proud to see Jin Taekyung doing his best to endure it, though it saddened him, too.

That was all.

So why did something in his chest still ache? Why did Jin Taekyung's figure keep wavering before his eyes even as he looked at the world around him?

Damn it. I really am getting old.

Strangely, he didn't much mind.

He had witnessed that mysterious recovery with his own eyes, but it was Jin Taekyung—not anything else—who filled his heart.

Well, this isn't so bad either.

With a faint smile, Jeok Cheongang headed somewhere quiet. Sunlight filtered through the leaves onto his bare scalp.

"Captain."

"What?"

"Captain."

"Ah, what?"

"Captaiiin!"

"Stop calling me, you bastard. I'm not dead yet."

Despite my shouting, Hyuk Mujin's voice still trembled with tears. He gripped my sleeve in both hands and looked up at me with wet eyes.

"Then when are you going to pass away?"

"…Are you insane? You sound like you're praying for me to die."

"You were unconscious for seven whole days and nights. I really thought you were going to die."

Taishan, who was on his hands and knees mopping the floor at my express command, promptly nodded.

"That's right. Taishan thought the Pavilion Master would never wake up and looked forward to it."

I was just beginning to feel touched when I noticed that something was wrong and blinked.

"Looked forward to it? Why?"

Namho, who had claimed the only chair on account of his age, muttered, "Why ask? The son of a bitch was looking forward to the funeral feast."

"No! Taishan worried so much about the Pavilion Master that he drooled whenever he thought of him!"

"…"

"…"

That bastard really had been looking forward to it.

Sama Pyo, who was practically Taishan's mother, met my eyes and lowered his head weakly.

"Pretend you didn't hear that. Even with ten mouths, I'd have nothing to say."

"Ten mouths? If Taishan had ten mouths—!"

"You'd eat ten times as much. Please, can someone muzzle him?"

Just as Assemblyman Namho of the Nanman Party formally introduced the Taishan Muzzle Bill, something whistled through the air.

Whoosh—crash!

The table—the one piece of furniture in the ruined quarters that had more or less kept its shape—splintered in a single blow.

Then came a cold voice.

"What… are you all doing in front of a patient?"

Everyone fell silent at Ju Hwaran's question. She had just smashed a table in front of that same patient.

Chapter 716

They say it's scarier when someone who's usually quiet gets angry.

Ju Hwaran was proving the point.

Clatter.

Wooden splinters rained from the hand of the Yongbong Escort Bureau's precious jewel. She was the human air purifier who had kept this jalapeño pepper party—reeking of old men and getting downright spicy—bearable.

Her usually gentle eyes and voice had turned sharp as thorns.

"Young Hero Taishan."

Taishan, her first target, flinched.

"Do you have any idea how much the Pavilion Master—how much Young Master Jin has gone through for us? How could you say something like that?"

"Ta-Taishan was wrong."

"I know you have an enormous appetite, but if you say anything ominous like that again, I really will muzzle you, just as Elder Namho suggested."

At Ju Hwaran's stern warning, Sama Pyo narrowed his brows and opened his mouth.

"Young Lady Ju, Taishan isn't a beast."

"Then should I muzzle you instead of Taishan?"

"…"

"Well?"

Sama Pyo considered this for a moment, then answered with a solemn expression.

"Come to think of it, an occasional muzzle might help him manage his diet."

"Be more careful from now on. I know you meant no harm, but that was too much."

"…Understood. I'll have a word with him."

With his proposed muzzle bill narrowly defeated, Namho muttered mournfully, "I'd hoped to see that bastard muzzled before I died…"

But he couldn't escape Ju Hwaran's attention either.

"Elder Namho."

"H-huh?"

"You're an elder. You should act like one. Swearing like that in front of a patient who hasn't even recovered isn't a good look."

"What? A patient?"

Namho eyed my face, positively glowing after all those level-ups and days of rest. He looked unconvinced.

“Never mind that. Where would you find a worse foulmouth than Jin Taekyung? Why are you coming after me all of a sudden—”

Tap.

I saw it clearly. Just as Namho was about to continue his protest, Hyuk Mujin discreetly jabbed him in the ribs with an elbow.

Translated into modern terms, that little gesture said:

Don’t kill the mood. Just say “for real, lol.”

Namho had decades of spy work behind him. His eyes darted around before he bowed his head in resignation.

“Understood. I’ll be careful.”

“Good. Next, Young Hero Hyuk—what are you doing?”

“I’m massaging the Captain’s shoulders to help him recover from all his hard work.”

Right. They didn’t call him Hyukroach for nothing.

Ju Hwaran smiled approvingly at the sight of Mujin deftly massaging me, then turned to the last person in the room.

“Captain Song.”

A tremor ran through Song Ilseom’s pupils. He had remained silent from beginning to end.

“I haven’t said anything.”

“I know. Keep it that way.”

“…Understood.”

With her final target dealt with, Ju Hwaran looked at me.

The moment our eyes met, my mouth opened on reflex.

“I’m sorry. I apologize. I was wrong.”

“What?”

“Yes?”

“What are you apologizing for?”

“Oh. Nothing. I just…”

I felt like I had to. Survival instinct, maybe.

I shot a look at Hyuk Mujin, who was now diligently massaging my legs.

What happened? Why is Young Lady Ju like this?

He answered with a look of his own.

She was worried sick about you, Captain. Just let it go.

Even so. The air feels different. The air.

If you can’t read the room, at least keep your mou—

“What are you two doing?” Ju Hwaran asked suddenly.

“…!”

"…!"

Mujin's hands flew twice as fast.

"What do you mean? I'm massaging the Captain's legs. Oh, these muscles are really knotted up. Should I press harder?"

Something felt wrong. I cautiously caught his arm.

"That's enough. Stop."

"Huh? Why?"

"No, it's… fine now."

"Our Captain is doing it again. You like it because it feels good, don't you?"

"No. I said it's fine. You must be tired too, so stop."

"Don't be shy. I, Hyuk Mujin, can do anything for my Captain as his right-hand man. You saw that, didn't you, Young Lady Ju? That's how well our Captain takes care of his people."

As Mujin turned to Ju Hwaran and laughed heartily, I sent him a Sound Transmission in despair.

—That wasn't my leg just now…

"…!"

—So get your hand off me right now, you bastard. Before I break your wrist.

After a brief silence, Mujin slowly withdrew his hand.

I wanted desperately to smack the back of his head as he stared at me with a gaze filled with a mixture of awe and fear, but I barely managed to hold myself back in front of everyone else.

Then again, maybe…

No. That's going too far.

I let the thought go and looked around at each of their faces.

Only a few days ago, I'd thought I might never see them again. Our situation had been that bad. Everything ahead of us had been lost in fog.

But now that we were all gathered together like this, alive, I was overcome with emotion all over again.

The fact that not one of them had died filled me with joy.

"I'm glad. Really."

At my single sentence, which broke the brief silence, everyone's eyes widened. Then they smiled faintly.

That was enough.

We'd grown close enough to understand what the others felt.

It took a while to hear the whole story.

We'd lived through the same stretch of time, but in different places, facing different things. Their story also covered the seven days and nights I'd spent unconscious.

"I really thought we were going to die. You weren't there, Captain, and we were tied up. Then that Blood Monk we'd only heard stories about stepped right off the swift ship. I mean… wow."

"If we hadn't recognized Great Hero Jeok, there would have been a fight. The Nanman warriors with us were itching for one."

"I thought it was all over. We were supposed to be bringing reinforcements to save you, and instead a fiend called the Blood Monk appeared."

They gave me more detail than Jeok Cheongang had.

The Nanman warriors hadn't believed the Blood Monk's identity at first. Then the bandits from the Water Dragon Stronghold—all of them sporting bruises around their eyes—stepped forward to confirm that he was the Fire King. The fight ended before it began.

Jeok Cheongang rushed to the Nanman Beast Palace with all his strength. By the time the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and Nanman scouts arrived a step behind him, everything was over.

"When we saw you collapse, Captain, I really thought you'd died. You were covered in blood, and there was nothing around you but blood and corpses…"

I was about to interrupt Mujin. If the state of my perfectly healthy body came up, how could anyone *not* be suspicious?

But before I could speak, Ju Hwaran went on.

"Great Hero Jeok reassured everyone. He said you'd only collapsed from exhaustion."

I asked, feeling uneasy.

"…What exactly did the Old Master—no, my master—say?"

"Hmm. I'm not sure. Everyone was in such a panic. But I remember him saying you hadn't been seriously injured because he'd arrived in time. Palace Lord Yayul agreed."

Namho nodded and chimed in.

"It was heavenly luck. Heavenly luck. No matter how powerful that bastard is, how could he have survived that hellscape? Two of the Ten Kings had stepped in. Even the Southern Heaven Demon Empress wouldn't have been able to do anything."

That wasn't quite what had happened.

I nodded anyway.

This was unmistakable protection. Jeok Cheongang and the Beast Miao King had taken action to conceal my secret and keep people from becoming suspicious.

The Baekcheon Unit survivors will keep quiet too. Their loyalty is to the Beast Miao King.

The dead couldn't talk. Most of the fighting that day had taken place in the Inner Palace, and most of the people there had died.

As long as the survivors said nothing, the secret would hold.

Even though I've grown close to them, I can't tell them.

In the modern world, people called things they couldn't explain Magic or miracles.

Here in Murim, they would use another word.

Demon.

Supernatural powers beyond anyone's understanding were bound to inspire fear. I wanted as few people as possible to know about the System—about this ability of mine.

Though what was done was done.

I had no idea what consequences my unavoidable choice that day would bring. Still, I was glad the person who'd seen it up close was Jeok Cheongang. I knew what kind of man the Beast Miao King was, too, and that put me at ease.

"Captain?"

"Huh?"

"What are you thinking about so hard?"

I must have been lost in thought for a while. Mujin was watching me suspiciously, so I waved a hand.

"Nothing. My mind wandered for a second. Go on."

"Oh, right. Where was I?"

"…Did you hit your head?"

"No. Maybe it's from someone smacking me in the back of it so often."

He glanced at me, leaving no doubt who he meant.

"I think I told you we gathered the dead and cremated them. You know all the chieftains who sided with Baeksang and then ran away were thrown into the underground prison, right?"

"More or less."

"Oh, and I heard Great Chieftain Yohi asked to be punished herself."

"Yohi did?"

"Yes. Great Hero Yayul seemed willing to forgive her, but she voluntarily entered the underground prison."

I hadn't expected Yohi to go that far. In a way, though, it made sense.

She'd repented too late, but she *had* joined Baeksang for wealth and power. Nearly dying must have taught her something.

She chose it herself. She must have thought it was the right thing to do.

I listened as they went on.

More Nanman people than ever were staying at the Nanman Beast Palace, working to restore the ruined Inner Palace and repair the considerable damage to the Outer Palace. Young Palace Lord Yayul Mok was so busy he barely had a moment to breathe.

“We sent word to him, but I don’t know if he can come right away,” Mujin said. “Lately, we can barely catch a glimpse of him.”

“I can imagine. The Beast Miao King must be just as busy.”

“Great Hero Yayul… You probably won’t see him either—not just us, but anyone else.”

“What?”

“He disappeared two days ago. I hear the leadership is already in an uproar.”

“…!”

Chapter 717

Seven days and nights could feel long or short, depending on the person.

But for the Nanman Beast Palace, it was nowhere near enough time to repair all the damage.

The demonic qi that had poured from the rift was gone, but its aftermath remained. Countless people had died. Some had lost their families and homes. Others must have been afraid the disaster could return at any moment.

And the Beast Miao King disappeared in the middle of all that?

I frowned, thought it over, then asked, “Tell me exactly what you know.”

Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head. “Uh, sorry, but it isn’t much. Like I said, the Nanman leadership is in an uproar. They even discussed casting a net over heaven and earth to find Great Hero Yayul.”

I could hardly blame them. The Palace Lord, the one person they needed to rally around in a crisis, had vanished.

They were probably worried Dark Heaven had made another move, too.

An assassination. Or a kidnapping.

Maybe I was getting ahead of myself, but neither was impossible. The Beast Miao King had been badly injured in his fight with the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. His martial prowess was extraordinary, and Jeok Cheongang had reached him in time to help, but he couldn’t have recovered in just a few days.

“So what did the search turn up?”

Mujin tilted his head. “What search?”

“…Did you actually hurt your head? You’ve forgotten what you said a moment ago?”

“Oh. The net over heaven and earth.” He slapped his forehead. “I only said they discussed it.”

“Huh?”

“They called it off.”

Called it off? Over something this serious?

I blinked, then asked, “Did Dark Heaven take over the Nanman Beast Palace while I was asleep?”

“The leadership? I don’t think so.”

“Then they’re searching in secret so they won’t alarm the tribespeople?”

“I don’t think so either.”

“Then why the hell aren’t they looking for their Palace Lord?”

“Why are you asking me? He isn’t my Palace Lord.”

Whack!

Mujin finally earned himself another point toward his back-of-the-head mileage. He crumpled with a silent scream.

Namho clicked his tongue at the sight of him writhing on the floor, then turned to me.

"Ordinarily, the leadership would have done something. Cast a net over heaven and earth, sent warriors to search in secret—anything."

I lowered my fist. "But they did nothing?"

"They had no choice. Someone stopped them."

"Someone?"

"What choice did they have? This wasn't some nobody who'd crawled in off the street. The great Fire King himself told them to drop everything."

"…!"

"He reportedly told them that if the Palace Lord didn't appear by midnight two days later, he would step in personally, so they should shut their mouths and focus on calming the people. The Young Palace Lord agonized over it, but in the end, he listened to the Fire King. The other chieftains had no choice either."

Jeok Cheongang—and Yayul Mok, too?

My surprise didn't last long. I thought for a moment, then nodded.

"Midnight two days later. That's tonight, isn't it?"

"That's right."

"I see."

"*I see?* That's all?"

"What else is there to say? If Ol—no, if Master said to drop it, then we should drop it."

Namho stared at me, then smacked his lips. "That's quite a bond of trust between master and disciple."

"His personality is terrible, but he has his reasons for doing things."

"Would that bond hold if I told him what you said about his personality?"

"…Things would get heated. Do you want to see me wake up in Henan?"

"Why even ask? Of course—"

His answer had come without a moment's hesitation. Then he glanced toward someone and continued in a mournful voice.

"Of course I'll keep it a secret. Naturally."

"…?"

What was that? Had Ju Hwaran just given him an axe-eyed glare?

But her eyes were curved into a smile when I looked. I must have imagined it. I probably wasn't fully awake yet.

Smack.

I patted my cheeks and stretched. My stiff bones cracked, and I felt lighter than ever.

I'm in perfect shape.

Between leveling up and resting for seven days and nights, my body couldn't have been better. The nightmare had left me in a foul mood, but that would pass.

Someone else is probably feeling the same way.

I put on a sleepy face for the others.

"Ah, I'm tired after talking so much for the first time in a while. Could you all give me a moment alone?"

Being a patient had its advantages. People accepted whatever I said without question.

Once they were gone, I slipped out of the pavilion through the window.

It was only a guess.

If he isn't there, no big deal. If he is, then great.

But the moment I entered a remote patch of grass that no one ever visited, my guess became certainty.

"Oh, there you are."

Rustle.

The grass stirred faintly at my greeting. At the same instant, a streak of light shot toward me.

Whoosh—crack!

The dagger flew straight toward the space between my brows. I caught it without even looking, and the blade began to glow red, unable to withstand the heat of the Scorching Yang Qi in my hand.

Drip. Hissss.

Molten metal fell to the ground. Only then did I remember I was still wearing my mask. I threw both hands up.

"It's me. Jin Taekyung."

A moment later, faint sounds of air splitting came from above. Several figures landed among the thick grass.

One, two, three… seven.

Exactly as many as I'd sensed. And I knew who they were.

"The Seven Miao Tigers, right?"

Step.

"Please forgive our rudeness."

The man in front stepped forward and removed his mask, revealing a good-natured face I recognized from the underground prison.

"We never did exchange names. I'm Wonhu of the Seven Miao Tigers. It's an honor to meet you, Great Hero Jin, Benefactor of Nanman."

"It's an honor to meet you, Great Hero Jin."

The others followed him in awkward but respectful fist-palm salutes.

I let out a quiet laugh. "Benefactor? I should be thanking you. You helped me a great deal that day."

At the mention of the underground prison, Wonhu smiled too.

"Think nothing of it. Without you, we would all have been as good as dead. Or… become mindless monsters."

His smile faded on those bitter words. He sighed, then looked at me with some uncertainty.

"But how did you know to come here?"

"I've been here once before. I came to see Great Hero Yayul."

Wonhu nodded as though that explained it. "That must have been the day he vanished without a word, even to us, his personal guards. We were quite alarmed."

"Yes. Yayul Mok—or rather, the Young Palace Lord—brought me here."

"No one comes here anymore. It's an ideal place for a private conversation."

"I can see that now."

The Outer Palace alone was enormous, large enough to pass for the capital of a small country. No one had any reason to wander into a secluded patch of grass where even the path had disappeared.

"Then, Great Hero Jin, are you perhaps…"

"Yes. I came to see Great Hero Yayul. I had a feeling he'd be here."

"Hmm."

Wonhu let out a low hum and stared at me. Then, instead of the answer I had expected, a quiet command slipped from his lips.

"Make way."

The Seven Miao Tigers standing behind him flinched in unison.

"Big Brother."

"But our lord ordered us not to let anyone in…"

"I won't say it twice."

At Wonhu's firm voice, the Seven Miao Tigers hesitated for a moment before sighing heavily and splitting apart to either side.

"I trust you know where to find him. I'll take my leave."

Wonhu gave me another awkward fist-palm salute and started to turn away. Then he stopped and looked back.

"I swear by heaven and earth, every person in Nanman, myself included, will remember what you did for us."

I felt the same way. I'd remember their help until I died, and I was grateful they were still alive.

I gave the Seven Miao Tigers a nod and made my way through the thick grass.

A few moments later, a crumbling old shrine came into view.

Step.

I made no attempt to hide my approach. Through the holes in its door and the gaps where the corners had worn away with age, I could see someone's back.

"May I come in?"

No answer came. I went inside.

Screeech.

The old floor shrieked as soon as I stepped on it.

"Whoa. You might want to oil this thing."

I glanced around as I spoke. A low voice came from the broad-backed man sitting cross-legged before me.

"It's fine. It's been like that for a long time."

"True. Great Hero Yayul would know better. You said you always hid here whenever you caused some major incident as a child."

"…Did I?"

"Have you forgotten already? You told me last time."

"I must have told you all sorts of things."

It wasn't that he didn't remember. He was grieving for someone who was no longer in this world.

Someone who had always hidden in this old shrine with him.

I watched the Beast Miao King's back for a moment, then asked, "Why did you disappear? You could have said something before you left."

"I felt like it."

"Everyone's worried. They keep asking where our Palace Lord went."

"So you came looking for me?"

"I was out for a walk. You should get back before 'our Palace Lord' becomes 'your Palace Lord.'"

"Palace Lord."

The Beast Miao King let out a quiet, humorless laugh and muttered in an empty voice,

"Do you think… I have the qualifications to be a Palace Lord?"

"Hmm. That depends on why you came here."

"Why?"

“If you’re going to brush me off with ‘I felt like it’ again, then you might as well quit being Palace Lord. Not that I’m qualified to tell you what to do.”

A brief silence passed before he spoke.

“It hurt. More than I could bear.”

“Because of what?”

“Because I failed to protect them. The countless tribespeople who followed me—and my one and only sworn brother, suffering right beside me.”

“…”

“Do you know which of those hurt me most?”

I didn’t answer. The Beast Miao King went on.

Chapter 718

“Despite all those deaths, the person I grieved for most was Baeksang.”

The Beast Miao King’s low voice reached me. I stayed silent for a moment before asking, “Is that why you left? Because you thought it was wrong to feel that way?”

“To become the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace means putting this land and its tribespeople before anything else. But I became trapped by my personal feelings.”

I could see his enormous back, like a thousand-year-old megalith. Yet the back of the giant who had supported Nanman for so many years looked pitifully small at that moment, like a child’s.

“Do you know what I was thinking when I faced Baeksang for the last time?”

I could guess, but I said nothing. The person who knew Baeksang best—and who had suffered most because of him—was right in front of me.

“I wanted to save him somehow.”

“…”

“Even in that horrific scene, I wanted to save that bastard Baeksang, who had betrayed everyone in this land, myself included, and help him run far away.”

They weren’t related by blood, but they were sworn brothers, as close as family. The Beast Miao King must have wanted to save Baeksang however he could. He must have wanted to absolve the man who had served as Dark Heaven’s hunting dog while the child he’d believed dead was held hostage.

But Baeksang himself had refused.

“He probably knew, too. That I was hesitating. That must be why he made that choice.”

The Beast Miao King’s murmur faded into the silence. The emotion in his voice was grief over being forced to end the life of his sworn younger brother—the man he had cherished more than his own life—with his own hands. It was also self-reproach for abandoning his duty as Palace Lord because of his personal feelings.

“One diseased tree caused the forest to die. Yet the forest keeper is now pacing in front of the diseased tree that has already fallen. Could you call such a person a forest keeper?”

I had been listening quietly to the Beast Miao King’s story. Then I broke the long silence.

“Great Hero Yayul, I’m asking you this in all seriousness…”

My voice trailed off. Even now, I wasn’t sure I should say it. But I had to get that devastated forest keeper back on his feet, even if it meant crossing the line a little. Or a lot.

“Are you fucking stupid?”

"…!"

I could sense his agitation even from behind. I'd already started, though, so I pressed on.

"What, is the Palace Lord some kind of god of heaven and earth? Don't you have human emotions?"

"You…"

"Let's be honest. Someone who spent their entire life with you, someone like family, just died. Who in this world could be fine after that? Are you supposed to be sadder just because other people died, too?"

The Beast Miao King took a moment to answer my barrage of blunt questions.

"Jin Taekyung, you as well?"

I nodded.

"Of course I would. What's so special about a bastard like me?"

"…"

"People around me can praise me as a chivalrous hero or a Great Hero, but I'm still a person in the end. Why would a Palace Lord be any different?"

I answered without hesitation. His broad back shifted.

Rustle.

He slowly turned his head. For the first time since I'd entered the old shrine, I saw his face. He looked utterly haggard.

"They were also Nanman people I had to protect."

"And you protected them. Even after being branded a traitor, you came back despite the danger. It was thanks to you that countless others could be saved."

I continued quietly.

"The diseased trees have fallen, but the forest hasn't died. It needs its forest keeper more than ever."

Many people had been sacrificed in this incident. But ironically, Nanman would grow even stronger.

Because Baeksang had not been the only diseased tree in the vast forest called Nanman.

The other chieftains. No—the traitors.

Baeksang had joined forces with Dark Heaven for his child. They had followed him for nothing but their own safety and power.

Those were the trees that should have been cut down long ago, trees sick with greed. More than twenty chieftains had shaken their branches, and countless leaves had fallen into bloody water. But the forest had survived.

Under the single banner of the Nanman Beast Palace, its people would come together and flourish. And only one person could raise that banner before all of Nanman.

"Let's go back. Then that father and son can rest easier too."

I was speaking to the Beast Miao King, but my eyes were elsewhere. He followed my gaze.

"You knew?"

"I noticed them as soon as I came in. Everything else in here is covered in dust. Those aren't."

I walked forward. Between the faded murals and dozens of stone statues I couldn't identify stood two memorial tablets that hadn't been there on my last visit.

Neither bore a name. I knew who they were for.

Baeksang. Baekhwi.

I said their names silently—the names even the person who had made the tablets by hand couldn't bring himself to carve. Then I lowered myself and bowed.

Once. Then again.

When I turned after the second bow, the Beast Miao King was staring at me, his face stiff.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"…I didn't expect it."

"What, did you think I'd knock the tablets over?"

"You might have. Especially Baeksang's, after what he did."

Damn it. Fair enough.

After everything that had happened, I could have split Baeksang's tablet in half and spat on it and called it self-defense.

But…

"I just wanted to do this. That's all."

What was this filthy, bitter feeling?

I looked back at the tablets and thought I might finally have a name for it. Perhaps it was sympathy. Perhaps empathy.

It's too late. I've gone down a road I can't turn back from, and I won't stop.

For an instant, I seemed to hear Baeksang's voice again, as I had in the dark underground prison. I looked at the blank tablet and asked a question he would never hear.

If I'd been you, what road would I have taken?

No answer came. Not from the tablet, and not from anywhere deep inside me.

If there really is such a thing as an afterlife, I hope that bastard—someone I could tear to pieces without feeling satisfied—gets to live an ordinary life unlike this one.

I hope he can spend a peaceful life without losing anyone or sacrificing anyone, together with the child he missed so terribly.

Damn it. How many people died because of him?

I knew every villain had a story. That wasn't what made this feel so rotten.

It was the thought that I might have walked the same road as Baeksang. I could imagine how desperately he'd struggled against the circumstances he'd been given.

In the end, this was all I could say.

"…Don't commit any sins over there, you goddamn bastard."

As I muttered the words, reddish light slipped through a gap in the shrine door and fell across the two tablets. As though that were their answer.

Then, the next moment, a deep voice pierced my ears.

"The sun's already setting."

Creeeak.

The old floorboards screamed. At last, the giant unfolded his crossed legs and rose from his seat, staring at me with calm eyes.

"If we head straight to the Inner Palace, we should still make it back in time for dinner."

"…!"

"Come. We should return before it gets any later."

I looked at him, let out a quiet laugh, and nodded.

Nanman's forest keeper had returned.

Two days passed.

When the Palace Lord, who had disappeared without a word, returned, the leadership—which had been thrown into confusion—quickly regained its stability. After taking a short rest at everyone's urging, the Beast Miao King summoned me the following day.

Or rather, he summoned Jeok Cheongang and me.

Jeok Cheongang arrived at the meeting room hastily thrown together over seven days and nights. The moment he saw the Beast Miao King sitting there, he said,

"Look how you've grown, our little Miao King. Sitting in the seat of honor and everything."

"…Oh. My apologies. Force of habit."

"No, I understand. So you'll understand this old man's habit of using the Flame Divine Palm on anyone who forgets his manners."

Whoosh!

The Beast Miao King had experienced that habit during the Great Faction War. Bandages and all, he swiftly vacated the seat of honor and gestured toward it.

"Please sit, Old Master Jeok."

"Oh, it's fine. You're injured. No need to go that far."

"…"

"Enough. Sit down. I don't care for some wet-behind-the-ears brat summoning me, but I'll let you say your piece."

The Beast Miao King seemed confused by the gangster-like way of speaking he hadn't heard in a long time, so I opened my mouth politely.

"Just tell him what you need to. That means he's listening."

"…Then, Old Master Jeok, may this junior speak?"

"He really hates being asked questions in return. You're still not fully recovered, so if you don't want to suffer something nasty, speak right away."

"…Understood."

Unlike the Jeok Cheongang in his memories, the one sitting before him looked much younger. The Beast Miao King glanced at him before carefully opening his mouth.

"I asked you to join us, Old Master Jeok, because I wished to consult you about a grave matter."

"A grave matter?"

"Yes."

"I hear the cleanup has been going well. Have you found a trail leading to Dark Heaven?"

"I wish we had, but no. In a way, this problem is even more troublesome…"

"Enough preamble. Get to the point before I shorten your life."

This man really hasn't changed.

The Beast Miao King looked at Jeok Cheongang with exactly that thought in his eyes, then took something from inside his robes and placed it on the table.

Thud.

It was something wrapped in thick cloth. But everyone in the room, myself included, could sense the ominous energy seeping out from within.

As the air suddenly grew heavy, Jeok Cheongang muttered as though groaning.

"…Demonic qi?"

The Beast Miao King nodded grimly.

"Yes. Extremely pure and powerful demonic qi. I couldn't entrust it to anyone else in Nanman, so I've kept it with me."

Their voices seemed to recede, as distant as echoes.

I thought I knew where that demonic qi had come from and what lay beneath the cloth. From the deep darkness, the guardian spirit's final roar rang in my ears once more.

"It's the sacred stone. The one the guardian spirit carried."

"As you guessed. Though it is no longer a sacred stone."

Rustle.

The Beast Miao King answered in a troubled voice and peeled back the cloth. Instead of warm, dazzling radiance, a stone filled with murky darkness was revealed.

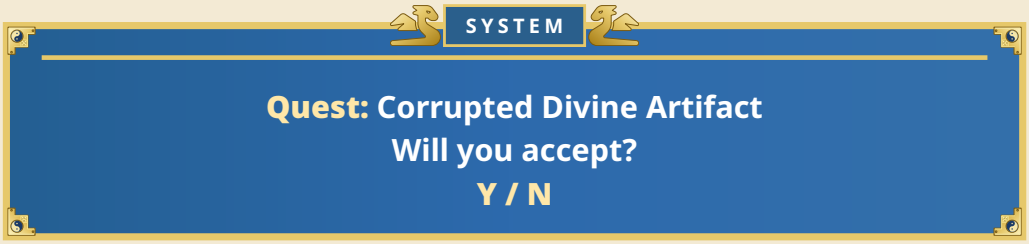
It had absorbed all the demonic qi flowing from the rift. Now, it was something that ought to be called a demonic stone, and the Beast Miao King's gaze sank deeply as he looked at it.

"I'm suppressing its demonic qi for now, but we can't leave it like this forever. That's why I asked you and Old Master Jeok here—to decide what to do with it."

At that moment—

Ding.

A clear chime rang out, utterly at odds with the murky darkness before me, and a holographic window appeared in midair.



Chapter 719

SYSTEM

Quest: Corrupted Divine Artifact
Will you accept?
Y / N

That wasn't the only holographic window to appear before me. I quickly scanned the information for the new Quest.

SYSTEM

Quest
Corrupted Divine Artifact
The sacred stone that once protected this land has lost its original form.
Consumed by demonic qi, it is a spark that could ignite another calamity. You must dispose of this Corrupted Divine Artifact by any means.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Dispose of Corrupted Divine Artifact (Incomplete)
Reward: Varies according to how the mission is carried out
Failure: Increase in the Corrupted Divine Artifact's demonic qi

After reading the Quest information window to the end, I muttered quietly to myself.

Accept.

SYSTEM

You have accepted the Quest **Corrupted Divine Artifact**!

Unlike some of the Quests I'd been more or less forced into, this one gave me a choice. But as far as I was concerned, refusing wasn't an option.

I can't keep suppressing the demonic qi forever.

The sacred stone—no, the Corrupted Divine Artifact—was a bomb that could go off at any moment. We were lucky the Beast Miao King had been keeping it. An ordinary Peak master couldn't have withstood the demonic qi inside it.

Like the Quest says, we have to deal with it somehow.

How many people had we lost closing the rift? For the sake of the guardian spirit that had thrown itself into it at the very end, I couldn't let that bomb go off.

I wasn't the only one who thought so.

"Demonic qi of this magnitude… This won't do."

Jeok Cheongang muttered with a frown, then gestured toward the Beast Miao King and me.

"Stand aside. This old man will handle it."

As if he had guessed what Jeok Cheongang meant, the Beast Miao King's eyes widened.

"Old Master Jeok, surely you don't mean…"

"Exactly what you think. If it might cause trouble, we pull it out by the roots."

"But this… won't be easy to destroy."

Jeok Cheongang's answer was short.

"For you, maybe."

"…"

"I can do it."

That was some fucking macho-man talk.

One sentence had silenced even the Beast Miao King, the beastliest man in Nanman. Jeok Cheongang slowly reached out.

Whoosh.

Scorching Yang Qi gathered around his hand, giving off such terrible heat that the haze rising on every side made the air seem to warp.

But—

"Old Master."

The words slipped out after a moment's thought. Jeok Cheongang stopped just as he was about to strike.

"What?"

"I don't think you should do that."

"Why?"

"I gave it some thought, and I have a feeling things could get ugly if we mess with it carelessly."

"What?"

His eyes widened at my serious tone.

"You mean you actually thought?"

"…"

Jeok Cheongang looked at my thoroughly deflated expression, cleared his throat, and opened his mouth.

“If we leave it like this, it will become a source of trouble sooner or later. We need to deal with it as quickly as possible.”

“I know.”

“Then why stop me? Don’t you trust this old man?”

“Oh, come on. Why would you say that? If I can’t trust you, Old Master, who can I trust?”

That was my answer. In truth, about half of me did have doubts.

Not because I distrusted Jeok Cheongang. I was worried about what might happen.

What if he doesn’t destroy it completely?

The Corrupted Divine Artifact was like the teacup in front of me. While the cup stayed intact, the tea stayed inside. Break the cup, and it would spill everywhere.

If we lose control of the demonic qi, we’ll have another goddamn disaster on our hands.

One mad tiger, however wildly it rampaged, could be beaten down. Demonic qi spreading through the area was another matter. If that happened, we’d be lucky if it was merely *troublesome*.

I had to stop Jeok Cheongang. No matter how much I trusted him, I couldn’t stake other people’s lives on this gamble.

Even if the chance is one in a thousand—or one in ten thousand—not now.

Too much blood had been spilled already.

People had died fighting to the bitter end. Others had lost their minds, become monsters, and died that way. Even people who had never held a sword had died in considerable numbers trying to escape that hellscape.

If the guardian spirit hadn’t sacrificed itself to close the rift, the casualties would have multiplied like a snowball by now…

Wait.

The guardian spirit?

A sudden sense of déjà vu came over me. Those words kept circling in my mind.

The memories from the day I first met it until now brushed past my eyes and ears one after another, racing toward a single thread of enlightenment.

And then—

“Ah.”

The sound escaped before I knew it.

Jeok Cheongang and the Beast Miao King stared at me as if wondering what the hell was wrong with me. Jeok Cheongang spoke first.

“Yeah, why the fuck are you suddenly throwing a fit all by yourself again? Let this old man in on it.”

“Have you perhaps thought of some brilliant strategy?”

Maybe. I didn't know whether it deserved to be called a plan. Not yet. But if I was right, it was worth trying.

At least we won't lose anything by trying.

I looked from the still-open Quest window to the two men waiting for an answer, then shrugged.

"Why don't you both come get some air with me?"

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Our little group raced through the wind. With only three tigers and three people, *group* might have been too grand a word.

Then again, it depended on who those people were. The two riding on either side of me made all the difference.

"I wondered how fast a beast could be, but this isn't bad. Comfortable saddle, too."

Jeok Cheongang inspected the tiger running beneath him with interest. The Beast Miao King, riding to my left, answered at once.

"He's one of the bravest and fastest tigers in the Nanman Beast Palace. He's descended from the one that fought alongside me in the Great Faction War."

"Oh-ho. That huge one crouching in front of the barracks? I remember him. I thought he looked familiar."

Yeah. Who needed an Azure Dragon on the left and a White Tiger on the right?

I had the Fire King on my left and the Miao King on my right. My chest swelled at the thought of that insane lineup. If the Southern Heaven Demon Empress came back to life, these two could take her apart.

The feeling of security was more comforting than a bowl of gukbap could have been.[3027] The quiet conversation between the two men reached my ears.

"The more I look at him, the more I like him. Good stamina, quick feet. Looks clever, too."

The Beast Miao King smiled with pride.

"I raised him with particular care. He was such a picky eater as a cub that I had quite a time of it. Whenever that happened, I even fed him milk myself."

"What? *You* fed him?"

"…It's a figure of speech. Not what you're thinking, Old Master Jeok."

Jeok Cheongang studied the Beast Miao King's massive pecs before nodding.

"If you say so."

"No, when you say it like that, it sounds as though—"

"Never mind. I'll take this one with me."

[3027] Gukbap is rice served in hot soup, a common comfort food in Korea.

The smile vanished from the Beast Miao King's face.

"Pardon?"

"Why are you asking again? Were you planning to make him run his legs off all the way back to the Central Plains?"

"O-of course not. But I raised the one you're riding like a son in my old age…"

"Give him to me."

"But—"

"Go on."

"…"

"If you don't want to, I'll take that one instead. He looks like a spiritual creature."

The Beast Miao King looked at the tiger Jeok Cheongang had pointed out and shook his head in alarm.

"Gasp. Anyone but him. I only borrowed him for a while in the first place."

"What if this old man were to take him?"

"I-I didn't raise him myself. And how could I, as a father, give away someone my son thinks of as a brother?"

"The sky's clear today. Your tongue's awfully long."

After a moment's silence, the Beast Miao King answered glumly.

"…Understood. You may have the one you're riding."

"Well, if you insist. I'll accept your generosity."

"…"

So much for my chest swelling with pride.

Was this really the senile Fire King I knew? The Fire King truly was a legend…

As I tried to steady my suddenly shrunken chest, the creature carrying me let out a low growl.

Grrr.

He glanced back at me. He seemed to know he'd narrowly escaped the clutches of the Fire King, that dog trader. I felt sorry for him and gently stroked his trembling white fur.

"It's okay, buddy. You survived."

Whine.

Muyaho let out a forlorn little cry, like a puppy that had lost its mother, and slowed down. He must have realized that showing off in front of Jeok Cheongang would only make it more likely he'd be dragged all the way to the Central Plains.

Fortunately, Jeok Cheongang's attention had already shifted.

"What's that…?"

His voice trailed off. Ahead of us stood a bare mountain, almost completely burned.

No, even that sorry-looking mountain had a name: Ailao Mountain. Everyone who lived in this land knew it.

Just as I was about to explain that to him, Jeok Cheongang's eyes flew open and he shouted,

"What shameless son of a bitch burned down these precious mountains, trees, and grass?"

"…"

"…"

For an instant, the Beast Miao King and I exchanged a heated glance. Then I answered with all the outrage I could muster.

"Dark Heaven."

Some truths are beautiful when left unknown.

Once Jeok Cheongang realized the sorry-looking mountain was our destination, he frowned.

"Did we come all this way to plant trees?"

"…I'm asking because I genuinely want to know. Just how crazy do you think I am?"

What a ridiculous question.

Today wasn't Arbor Day, and even if it had been, I wouldn't have planted any trees. I had come with these two to Ailao Mountain, which had been reduced to a bare mountain, for a purpose that had been decided from the beginning.

"This way."

The Beast Miao King soon realized where I was going.

"The Poisonblood Grounds. Or should I call it the Sacred Land now?"

It would have been stranger if he *hadn't* known. Yohi must have told him roughly what had happened, even if she'd left out the details.

I shook my head.

"They're different. The Poisonblood Grounds are the Poisonblood Grounds. The Sacred Land is the Sacred Land."

The two places were separate. The Poisonblood Grounds were a land of death made by human hands. The Sacred Land was Nanman's heart—a land of life.

Life itself.

I set the Corrupted Divine Artifact on the ground. Demonic qi drifted from it like mist, and Muyaho growled softly.

But though darkness had consumed it, its essence had not changed.

Whoosh…

The ground pulsed like a beating heart. A veil lifted from another world that had been hidden for countless ages.

Then I saw it: a space filled with warm radiance, and at its center, a small pond shining more brilliantly than anything else.

“Ah.”

“That’s…”

Jeok Cheongang’s and the Beast Miao King’s exclamations faded without either man finishing his thought.

But I knew what they had felt. And I knew what I had to do.

Purification.

Today, a new sacred stone would be born.

Chapter 720

Whew.

A cool breeze brushed past me. I took a small, deep breath and looked around.

The Sacred Land.

Could there be another place where those two words fit so perfectly?

But where I stood was only its body.

Even this Sacred Land has a heart of its own.

A place filled with the energy of life and Purification. The place that had brought my dying body back to life.

I walked slowly toward the distant pond.

There was no sun, yet the light falling from above was warm. Flowers and grass bloomed lushly in every direction.

Jeok Cheongang and the Beast Miao King stared at the bizarre space with stunned expressions. Their lips moved as though they were about to say something, but before long, they firmly shut their mouths and followed behind me.

Their patience didn't last long.

Splash.

I waded straight into the pond. Cold water soon rose to my waist, and Jeok Cheongang cried out in alarm.

"Th-that bastard…!"

Apparently he thought I meant to kill myself.

He looked ready to grab me by the collar and drag me out. Instead of explaining, I bit my pinky.

Crunch.

A faint sting. The skin split, and blood flowed.

But after giving the wide-eyed Jeok Cheongang a crooked grin, I plunged my hand into the clear water without hesitation.

One. Two. Three…

I counted slowly in my head before pulling it out. In barely thirty seconds, my pinky had healed completely.

Jeok Cheongang, who had looked ready to jump in after me, and the Beast Miao King, who had been trying to stop him, muttered in disbelief.

"What in the world…"

"…Everything Yohi said was true. All of it."

There was a reason people came up with the saying that seeing once was better than hearing a hundred times. I could talk until my mouth went dry, but showing them was faster.

It was a kind of performance.

It worked. And I'd confirmed something for myself, too.

The pond still works.

I'd been a little worried. Like a Golem collapsing when its core was destroyed, the Sacred Land might have vanished once demonic qi consumed the sacred stone.

But that concern vanished as cleanly as the wound on my pinky, replaced by a suspicion bordering on certainty.

This is it. The answer.

The System had never lied to me. It presented the facts as they were; finding a new path in its maddeningly plain text was up to me.

Just like now.

The Quest information said "by any means." I'm sure of it.

That was right. From the beginning, the mission I had been given was to *dispose of* the Corrupted Divine Artifact, not to *destroy* it.

I'd caught on rather late, but my memories of the guardian spirit had led me back to this place. To the pond that had healed me when I was near death and cleansed the impurities from my body.

Healing and Purification.

I didn't know where its mysterious power came from. I only knew I had no better option.

I walked toward the center of the pond.

Swish.

Gentle ripples spread outward from me. The pond wasn't very deep, and on its surface—clear enough to see through—I could see the face of a man stiff with tension wavering in the water.

Gulp.

I swallowed and looked at my clenched fist. I felt the hard surface of the Corrupted Divine Artifact—and the powerful demonic qi pulsing up between my fingers.

…If this backfires, we're in for a real shitshow.

I wasn't joking. That much demonic qi could ruin not just the pond, but the entire Sacred Land.

Then this place would become the real, true Poisonblood Grounds, and the guardian spirit—who had only just finished filing his move-in registration in the afterlife—would show up in my dreams every night and hiss at me.

But still…

What else am I supposed to do? There's no other option.

Fuck it. I don't know.

I squeezed my eyes shut and plunged the Corrupted Sacred Stone into the water.

Splash! Fwoooosh!

The calm surface broke. Spray shot up and soaked me from head to toe.

And then…everything went quiet.

"…?"

What the hell? Why was it so quiet?

I hesitated through a moment that felt like an eternity, then opened my eyes.

A little. Just a little.

And at the moment I cautiously peered through narrowed eyes—

Blub blub.

Bubbles rose to the surface.

Whooooooosh.

From the center of the pond, water mixed with murky darkness began to whirl into a vortex.

Which meant…

Fuck. I'm standing right on it.

The realization had barely struck when an enormous pillar of water surged up beneath my feet.

Kwaaaaaaah!

I had no time to react. Water and darkness filled everything around me.

Caught in the chaos that had rushed upon me without warning, I thrashed about with all my strength. No, I tried to. I would have, if I hadn't realized the truth a moment later.

"…!"

I could see it. Feel it.

Water and darkness spun fiercely around me. But so did fresh air and wind—things I couldn't have felt underwater.

Air? Wind?

I blinked and looked around.

I wasn't floating beneath the surface. The water that had risen to my chest was gone. Solid ground lay beneath my feet, while water and darkness swirled endlessly on every side.

It…wrapped around me?

There was no doubt. Instead of sweeping across my entire body, the enormous pillar of water had enclosed me. Beyond the darkness and waves blocking me in on every side, impossible and unbelievable scenes flashed past my eyes.

Fwoooosh!

This is…

I understood at once. What I was seeing wasn't a hallucination caused by extreme confusion or anything of the sort. It was simply the history of some place contained within this pond.

Or perhaps the memories of the divine artifact that had shared this land's fate since its birth.

"…The sacred stone."

I muttered the words like a groan and gazed with stunned eyes at the column of water walling me in on every side.

Time flowed through its ceaseless waves.

A sprout pushed up from barren ground and grew into a towering tree. Grass and flowers spread, and animals appeared one by one.

So fast.

The scenes reflected in the water changed in less than an instant. Day and night traded places dozens of times in the blink of an eye. On one day, thunder and lightning filled the world. On another, a mountain collapsed and erased a river.

Hundreds of years. Perhaps thousands.

Through it all, the sacred stone remained where it was. And others stayed beside it.

Horses. Monkeys. Leopards. Bears…

They differed in species and appearance, but I could hardly call them mere beasts.

Countless among them shone like stars in the night sky before fading away, and eventually, a snow-white White Tiger began guarding the sacred stone.

The guardian spirit.

Then darkness came. A darkness dreadful enough to make me shudder. Sticky, wicked qi surged through the waves.

After all those years, the memories had reached that day.

But the final guardian spirit charged forward, its white mane streaming behind it. With a roar, it bit and clawed at the darkness.

Until demonic qi seeped into the wounds across its body. Until the moment its blue-white eyes turned black.

And then every memory contained within the sacred stone ended as well.

No. Perhaps this was a new beginning.

Swish.

The water rippled again. The darkness vanished, and a face appeared in the pillar surrounding me.

The figure of a young man with his eyes squeezed shut as he immersed something in his hand deep into the pond was unmistakably familiar.

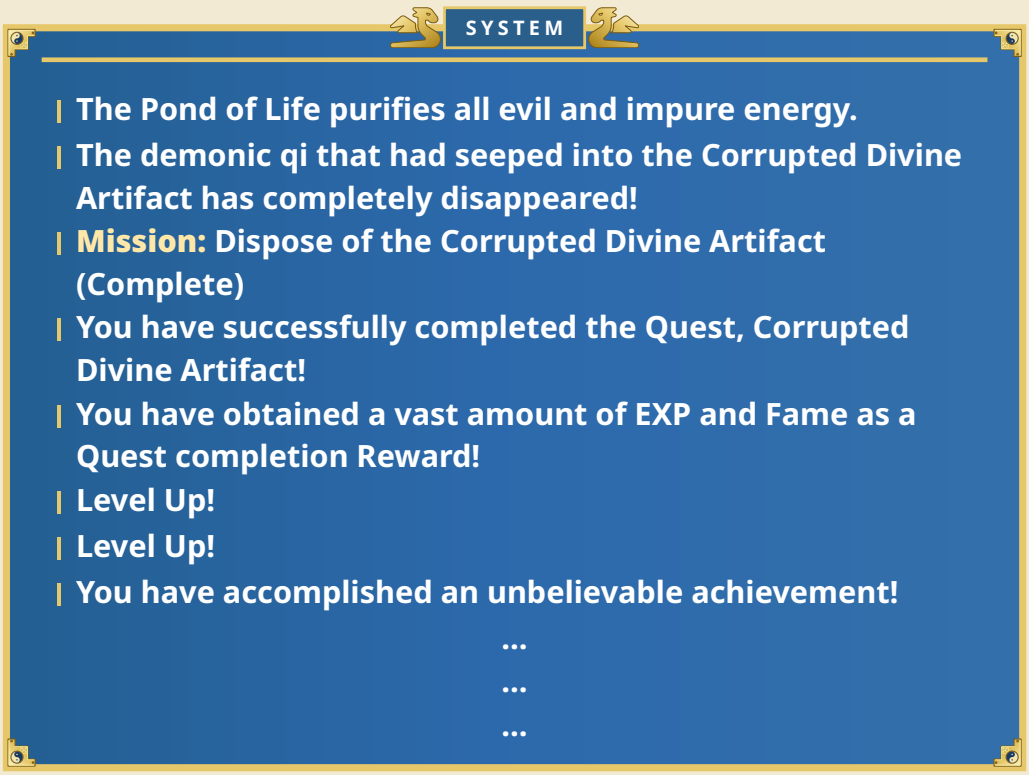
The sacred stone's newest memory began with me.

And that could mean only one thing.

Ding.

A clear chime rang in my ears. The darkness writhing in the pillar of water faded without a trace.

As I stared blankly at the sight, a translucent holographic window appeared before me.



Ding. Ding. Ding.

System notifications rang without pause, and holographic windows filled the air. But all of it felt distant. Through the slowly dispersing pillar of water, a single object shone.

Swish.

As if entranced, I reached out. The water parted before my hand.

It was smaller and lighter than a child's fist, yet impossibly warm. The moment my fingertips touched it—

Fwooooooosh!

Dazzling light swelled. At the same time, the column of water walling me in on every side shot into the sky and burst apart like an explosion.

Fwooooooosh!

The power of life spread endlessly beyond the hidden Sacred Land, toward some faraway place.

With the new sacred stone in my hand, I tipped my head back and looked up. Another clear chime rang out among the falling droplets.

Ding.

SYSTEM

The energy held within the Pond of Life becomes rain and seeps into every part of this land.
The earth will grow more fertile, the plants will stay green, and the wounded will be healed.
The Pond of Life has lost all its energy and dried up. But do not worry. Time has the power to change many things.
The sacred stone will remain in this land, as it always has. Together with a new guardian spirit.

A new guardian spirit?

Before I could grasp what that meant, I heard footsteps.

Thud.

A large forepaw came down on the dry ground where the pond had been.

Snow-white fur fluttered in a breeze that had come from somewhere, and the blue-white eyes, now clearer and more distinct, looked exactly like those of someone from my memories.

"...So it's you."

Grrrr.

Muyaho—no, the new guardian spirit—approached and rubbed its head against me.

Without saying a word, I stroked the back of its neck. Jeok Cheongang, who had watched the entire scene with a dazed expression, barely managed to part his lips.

"...Can't this old man take him with me?"

The Beast Miao King's face went stern.

"Would that be possible?"

Neither of them noticed the green leaf that had just poked up beneath the rain falling around them.

Nor did they know that the rain would soak all of Nanman for three days.

Chapter 721

Even now, nearly ten days after *that day*, restoration work was still underway at the Nanman Beast Palace.

The Inner Palace, its very heart, had been completely devastated. The Outer Palace had also suffered considerable damage in the aftermath of the battle.

Fortunately, by mobilizing all the warriors and beasts, they had managed to clear away most of the rubble in a short time. But considering all the houses and pavilions that still had to be built for the tribespeople who had suddenly lost their homes, the road ahead seemed endless.

“Right, we lift together on three. One, two.”

“Hngh!”

Grrrrind!

They combined their strength to lift a huge boulder, then hoisted thick timber onto bruised shoulders.

Despite the unending hard labor, no one complained. This was work for everyone’s sake.

The Nanman Beast Palace was a symbol to all who lived in this land, a home of the heart passed down from their ancestors. It no longer mattered which tribe the people beside them belonged to, what they wore or ate, or which local god they worshiped.

Everyone here had come for one purpose: to rebuild the Nanman Beast Palace.

That was why one middle-aged man had walked three hundred li[3028] to get here, too.

Whack!

The ax blade bounced off the thick timber, sending a sharp pain through his palm. He groaned before he could stop himself, and a young man came over.

“That’s not how you swing it. Let me see your hand.”

The middle-aged man held it out without thinking. He had inherited his family’s business and spent his life as a merchant. Now his palms were covered in blisters and blood.

“Ouch. That must hurt. You haven’t done much of this before, have you?”

“N-no, I haven’t.”

“You can’t do it with strength alone. Put your weight behind the ax and follow the grain. One clean whack. Want me to show you?”

The middle-aged man stared blankly at the young man speaking to him so affably.

Something about him felt unfamiliar. Not simply because they had never met. It was his appearance, and the halting way he spoke, almost like a child.

[3028] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); three hundred li is about 150 km (93 mi).

Then a thought struck him.

“Could you be…?”

“Han Chinese? Yes.”

“Ah, then you’re the one I’ve only heard about through rumors…”

“That’s right. I’m the one.”

“Oh! Ohhh!”

The young man gave him a warm smile.

“My name is Hyuk Mujin.”

“The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Tae… Wait. Mujin who?”

“Hyuk Mujin. The famous Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung’s right-hand man! The pillar of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan! The proud Vice Pavilion Master of the Murim Alliance’s Fire Dragon Pavilion!”

What the hell was wrong with this guy?

Hyuk…what?

Did Han Chinese people have names like that?

The middle-aged man stared at Hyuk Mujin with an uncertain expression, but just as he was about to pick up his ax again—

Tap. Tap-tap.

Raindrops suddenly began to fall.

At the same time, sighs escaped from the people working nearby. There was a mountain of work left to do, and rain would naturally slow them down.

“Damn it. Now it’s raining out of a clear sky.”

“What can we do? We’ll just have to think of it as a passing shower.”

“Come on! Let’s keep at it a little longer!”

The middle-aged man glanced up. There wasn’t a cloud in sight. Even for Nanman’s unpredictable climate, this was unusual.

Still, a little shower won’t hurt.

Perhaps it was because he was already soaked in sweat, but the sudden rain didn’t feel entirely unpleasant. The drops struck his palms and seemed to wash his wounds clean.

That feels good.

He closed his eyes without realizing it.

A hand clamped around his wrist.

Startled, he opened his eyes.

“What…is this?”

Hyuk Mujin’s face had gone rigid. He was staring at the middle-aged man’s palm.

Slowly.

The wounds were disappearing. No—healing.

The blisters that had filled both palms, the skin crushed and torn by swinging the ax…

The rain washed away the abundant blood, revealing new muscle and flesh beneath—paler and firmer than before.

“…!”

“…!”

They looked up at the sky at the same instant, eyes wide.

Boom. Boom. Booooom!

Through the sunlit rain came the sound of drums, announcing someone’s return.

A miracle.

Those two words explained everything. There was no other way to describe it.

Tap. Ssshhhh.

Rain had begun to fall. Warm rain that soaked buildings and earth, coaxed flowers and sprouts into bloom, and fell on the heads of every living thing.

It washed away their wounds and fatigue.

“My wound! It’s healed!”

“My body feels so light!”

“W-what in the world…?”

Grrr?

The people stood dazed until a lion’s roar rang out from somewhere.

“By order of the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, everyone outside!”

The shout, charged with powerful internal energy, reached every corner of the Outer Palace. Drawn by the command, people came out to find a massive White Tiger and three men standing before them.

Jeok Cheongang. The Beast Miao King. And Jin Taekyung.

“I’ve called them all out, just as you asked,” Jeok Cheongang whispered. “Now what?”

“Wouldn’t it be enough to tell them to come outside and get rained on? They’ll understand once they experience it themselves.”

At the Beast Miao King and Jeok Cheongang’s whispers, Jin Taekyung shook his head without hesitation.

Unlike those two martial artists to the bone, he had been born and raised in the modern world. He knew what marketing could do.

“We can’t just let them get wet and call it a day. We have to dress this up and sell it first.”

“Dress it up? Sell it?”

"What in the world are you talking about?"

"It's complicated. Think of it as a bit of political maneuvering."

Martial artists could reach the end of their lives without learning a thing about politics. Anyone born in twenty-first-century Korea knew better.

It was a ruthless world. Being bad at a game was enough to make people wish you dead.

Jin Taekyung, who had been called an orphan dozens of times in games he had logged into just for fun, knew the importance of politics better than anyone.[3029]

Make the guy who did well look like he failed, and the guy who failed look like he did well. And…

Make the guy who did well look even better. That was politics. Modern marketing.

He wasn't about to waste this opportunity.

It'd be a shame if everyone just went, "Wow, a miracle!" and left it at that.

He muttered inwardly, then took a deep breath. He shouted toward the people, filling his voice with internal energy.

"Listen, everyone! This holy rain was bestowed by the Earth Mother Goddess!"

The Earth Mother Goddess?

People blinked at the unfamiliar name. Beside him, the Beast Miao King frowned.

"What's that?"

"A god."

"We don't have a god like that here."

"We do now."

"…?"

What the hell is wrong with this bastard?

While the Beast Miao King stood speechless, Jin Taekyung went on.

"The Earth Mother Goddess is the mother of this land, and she is the One God!"

"…!"

"…!"

The One God.

The crowd gaped.

Nanman was home to thirty-two tribes and more than a hundred local gods—far more gods than tribes. And Jin Taekyung was telling them there was only one?

Nanman might have suffered a disaster and the Nanman Beast Palace might have gone to shit, but the faith they had held all their lives remained.

"What nonsense!"

"I've never even heard of an Earth Mother Goddess!"

[3029] Calling someone an orphan is a way of insulting their mother in online games.

"I know you have worked hard for Nanman, but how dare you utter such blasphemy! The Wood God I worship is the One God!"

"Don't bring the Wood God into this! The Fire God is the true god!"

"You little bastard!"

Yet Jin Taekyung looked pleased as he watched the believers grabbing one another by the collars and fighting.

Idiots.

Nanman's religious landscape was as chaotic as the era of the Five Barbarians and Sixteen Kingdoms.[3030] That would make things easier. Unlike them, he had evidence to back his claim.

"You fools! Can you stand in this holy rain and still not feel the Earth Mother Goddess's grace?"

His stern reprimand rang across the courtyard, and the noise vanished as if it had been washed away.

One tribesman, his fist drawn back for an uppercut, looked at the sky in confusion.

Ssshhhhhh.

Rain fell from a cloudless sky. It healed the sick and brought new shoots out of the earth. The sight gave him pause.

"B-but the Wood God…"

"So what did your Wood God do ten days ago? Even when I was setting fire to the mountain, it didn't do much."

"W-well…"

Jin Taekyung cut him off with another shout.

"Everyone gathered here must have seen it! The dazzling radiance of that day! The warmth!"

"…!"

"The miracle then and the miracle today were both blessings from the Earth Mother Goddess, who took pity on you!"

Uncertainty flickered across the people's faces.

They *had* seen and felt it all. And the rain falling on them now was another miracle.

"The Earth Mother Goddess…"

Even the name sounded warm and familiar. Saying it brought a mother's embrace to mind.

And she was the One God, too. The one and only One God.

"Th-then what are the other gods we've worshiped until now?"

Jin Taekyung answered without a moment's hesitation.

[3030] The Five Barbarians and Sixteen Kingdoms refers to a period of upheaval and competing states in Chinese history.

“You can’t compare the great Earth Mother Goddess to a bunch of lesser gods.”

“L-lesser gods…!”

“The Earth Mother Goddess bestowed this miracle and gave me a divine message: ‘Useless gods. The kind that aren’t worth knowing.‘ She told me to protect you from them.”

“Oh! Ohhh!”

“A miracle, and a divine message too!”

Excitement swept through the crowd. They were all shouting together now.

Jin Taekyung seized the moment and threw both hands into the air.

“Shout together! Earth Mother Goddess!”

“Earth Mother Goddess! Earth Mother Goddess!”

“Louder!”

“Earth Mother Goddess! Earth Mother Goddess!”

“Repeat after me. Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell!”

“Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell!”

“Those in Nanman who believe in the Earth Mother Goddess will be saved even after death, while those who do not believe will fall into a pit of fire when they die!”

“Wooooooah! O Mother Goddess!”

“Save us! Save this land!”

The tribespeople had become the Earth Mother Goddess’s sons and daughters before the Beast Miao King’s eyes. He stared at Jin Taekyung, stunned.

What the hell are you doing, you lunatic?

He wanted to stop him. He *had* to stop him.

He didn’t know what political maneuvering or dressing things up had to do with this, but the look in everyone’s eyes had already gone frighteningly wild. They screamed to the Earth Mother Goddess as though their throats might tear, their voices shaking heaven and earth.

“Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell!”

“Where’s that guy who said he believed in the Wood God?”

“There! That’s him! Throw him in the fire!”

“Gasp! No! I-I’ve already converted!”

“Prove it!”

“M-Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell!”

“He’s one of us! Stop tying him up! Now find the one who worshiped the Fire God!”

A wave of conversions overflowed in every direction.

The oppressive force radiating from thousands—tens of thousands—of people was so great that even Jeok Cheongang, who had privately wondered whether he should try believing in the Fire God, fell silent.

The Beast Miao King desperately wanted to put an end to this madness.

“E-enough now…”

He had barely managed to speak when Jin Taekyung’s voice rang out.

“Everyone, quiet! The Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace—the priest chosen by the Earth Mother Goddess—is about to speak!”

“Enough… What?”

“Please speak, Priest.”

“What kind of boss?”

Priest? Me?

Before the Beast Miao King could make sense of the word, countless eyes turned toward him.

A suffocating silence settled over the crowd. He was a well-liked Palace Lord, but he had never seen his people look at him with so much love and trust.

“…!”

He stood frozen as a statue. Then his lips parted.

“Mother Goddess Heaven. Unbeliever Hell.”

“Waaaaaaaaah!”

And so, under the care of the great Earth Mother Goddess, Nanman achieved true unity at last.

Chapter 722

The Earth Mother Goddess.

Warmth seemed to radiate from the name alone, and this One God turned all of Nanman upside down the moment she appeared.

It was a spectacular debut that swept away Nanman's religious scene—once every bit as fiercely competitive as Korea's idol market.

And then came the wave of faith.

No, the tide of fanaticism.

"Earth Mother Goddess! Earth Mother Goddess!"

"Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell!"

Those who believed in the Earth Mother Goddess would be saved even after death, while those who denied her would die and be thrown into a pit of fire.

Within half a day, her new sons and daughters were marching through the streets, shouting slogans. Before long, they began proselytizing.

"Hey, you. Wait a moment."

"Why, why do you ask?"

"Do you believe in any god?"

"Well, um… Ah, yes! I believe in the Earth Mother Goddess!"

"Mother Goddess Heaven."

"Pardon?"

"You don't know the slogan? You're a heretic! Unbeliever Heeell!"

"Eek! I'll convert! I'll convert!"

Jeok Cheongang watched the spectacle and summed up his thoughts in one short sentence.

"What a fucking shitshow."

Jeok Cheongang was an outsider, so his reaction ended there. But the Beast Miao King, who had somehow become the Earth Mother Goddess's priest, was half out of his mind.

"This… This isn't right. Our traditions… Our native faith…"

It didn't take him long, though, to realize what was happening.

"Wait. This…"

The Beast Miao King fell deep into thought, then murmured, "Not bad. No, this is actually great."

"You get it now? Nothing brings people together like religion."

Nanman was rebuilding, and for now everyone was pulling together. Even so, there was no denying that the Nanman Beast Palace was divided.

"You've been wondering what to do with the tribal chieftains we threw into the underground prison, haven't you?"

"…Yes. No matter what crimes they committed, each of them led a tribe."

He hadn't spared them out of some misplaced sympathy.

At its core, the Nanman Beast Palace was an alliance of thirty-two tribes, and more than twenty of their chieftains had taken part in the betrayal.

If he executed them all as traitors, some people were bound to resent it. People took their own side.

"For now, the people want them executed. But given time, problems will arise. They simply haven't surfaced yet."

Memories had a way of becoming kinder with time.

Once the chaos settled, people would probably begin to whisper.

Our chieftain was a decent man, though.

That's right. Baeksang tricked him. He couldn't help it.

Come to think of it, isn't it strange that so many chieftains were involved?

I could picture it all too easily.

Those cautious conversations would begin in small groups, spread throughout the Nanman Beast Palace, and eventually cause another rift.

"On top of that, the tribes whose chieftains were traitors involved in this affair will be subjected to the other tribes' silent contempt. That will lead to resentment between the tribes."

"But we can't just let them all go."

"They were blinded by wealth and glory and betrayed Nanman once already. Would a second betrayal be so difficult?"

No wonder the Beast Miao King had agonized over what to do with them. He needed a way to punish the traitors without tearing Nanman apart.

At least, that had been the case until the One God known as the Earth Mother Goddess appeared and performed an unprecedented miracle.

"Now is the perfect time. We can expose their crimes under the law, execute them, and root every weed out of this land!"

The law? Executions?

I clicked my tongue at the sight of his clenched fist.

He still doesn't get it.

"What?"

"The law is fine, but this is judgment. Divine judgment."

"Divine… judgment?"

"The men in the underground prison are traitors who joined forces with the Fiend known as Dark Heaven to corrupt this land. And you, Great Hero Yayul, are the

one and only priest. You received a divine revelation from the Earth Mother Goddess: kill every last one of those bastards and purify Nanman."

"…!"

"…!"

The Beast Miao King stared at me, wide-eyed. So did Jeok Cheongang, who had been listening beside us.

I could read the thoughts in their eyes.

Wait, he's spinning it like that?

Wow. Is this guy seriously insane?

What a pair of naïve old men.

Ten Kings be damned. Maybe spending their entire lives focused on martial arts had left them ignorant of how the world worked.

Even after leading the Nanman Beast Palace for so long, the Beast Miao King wasn't much more politically savvy than Jeok Cheongang.

No wonder Baeksang's faction ran rampant.

But who was I?

A proud citizen of Korea.

I had spent my whole life in a country with more churches than fried-chicken restaurants, where you could spot twenty-first-century martyrs carrying crosses near any subway station.

I decided to show the Beast Miao King, who still didn't understand what it meant to be a priest, the power he held.

"Now, repeat after me."

The Beast Miao King stared blankly at me, then echoed my words.

"Now, repeat after me."

"No, not that. We're starting now."

"Ah. Right."

"I am a priest."

"I am a priest."

"The Earth Mother Goddess is a god."

"The Earth Mother Goddess is a god."

"Good job. Now continue."

"I am a priest. The Earth Mother Goddess is a god."

"Excellent. Repeat it."

"I am a priest. The Earth Mother Goddess is a god. I am a priest. The Earth Mother Goddess is a god. I am… invincible!"

"…?"

That last part wasn't quite what I'd taught him.

Regardless, the Beast Miao King trembled with excitement, awakened to his role as the Earth Mother Goddess's priest. Then he took the first great step toward reforming Nanman.

"In the name of the benevolent Earth Mother Goddess, I convene the Tribal Grand Council!"

"…"

"…"

He really was a priest now.

The Tribal Grand Council began in the blink of an eye.

Partly because so few tribal chieftains were able to attend, but sending messengers probably hadn't been necessary anyway. The chieftains were already waiting for the Beast Miao King in a hastily prepared meeting room.

"Palace Lord!"

"It's just a rumor, isn't it? Tell us it's a rumor!"

"What is this about an Earth Mother Goddess all of a sudden?"

"Fuck, the tribespeople have gone completely insane. They're like Demonic Cultists during the Great Faction War!"

"This is absurd! Are you telling us to abandon the Wood God we've worshiped all our lives?"

They rushed at the Beast Miao King, their faces a mixture of disbelief and shock. But as soon as they heard what kind of effect launching the Earth Mother Goddess as a new brand could have on the market, they made their declarations in solemn tones.

"As tribal chieftain, I must set an example. I shall convert."

"The Tribal Grand Council supports you, Palace Lord."

"Wow, a united Nanman!"

"The Wood God? When it comes to gods, the Earth Mother Goddess is the one."

They were in charge for a reason. They caught on fast.

Of course, some people weren't so quick and came to confront the Beast Miao King.

"Palace Lord! How can this make any sense?"

"What exactly is the Earth Mother Goddess? And where did this nonsense about Mother Goddess Heaven and Unbeliever Hell come from?"

"It's poison! The Palace Lord has spread poison throughout Nanman!"

"Do you think we priests will stand by and watch? We would rather die than let this pass!"

Dozens of priests, every one of them very old.

They had spent their lives serving the local gods, but they confronted the Beast Miao King with voices that rang out loud and clear despite their age.

Until Jeok Cheongang opened his mouth.

“If you won’t let it pass, what are you going to do about it?”

“What did you say?”

“Well, listen to the way this young bastard talks to his elders.”

“Palace Lord! Punish that insolent man at once! Some nobody we’ve never even heard of, running his mouth like—”

“Fire King.”

“…?”

“…?”

“That’s my sobriquet. Fire King Jeok Cheongang.”

“…!”

“…!”

“I’ll let anyone a hundred or older off. The rest of you, heads to the floor.”

The fame of the Fire King Jeok Cheongang—or rather, his temper—was well known not only in the Central Plains but also throughout Nanman.

“Um, Palace Lord?”

“Ah, what a lovely downpour.”

“…”

When even the Beast Miao King, their final lifeline, looked off toward a distant mountain, the priests immediately got down with their heads to the floor and swore that from then on, they would keep their mouths shut about the Earth Mother Goddess no matter what.

“Honestly, we call ourselves priests, but we’ve never even seen the gods we serve. Isn’t that right?”

“Hahaha. True, true. But the Earth Mother Goddess has shown us a miracle herself. How extraordinary!”

“Um, Palace Lord. Might there be any positions left on the Earth Mother Goddess’s side? You would remain the priest, of course, but perhaps another role…”

“Ahem. Since you mention it, the gods we serve are all closely tied to this land, aren’t they? Perhaps we could join forces…”

“Exactly! The Earth Mother Goddess is the mother of this land. In a sense, she gave birth to all the gods!”

A fantastic collaboration: priests who didn’t want to lose their livelihoods and the Beast Miao King, who wanted to unite Nanman completely.

After a serious discussion, the Earth Mother Goddess emerged as a god with dozens of lesser gods under her. I had no desire for a religious war, so I lent a little help too.

“This is getting complicated. Why don’t we just make one?”

“Make what?”

“Well… I guess we could call it a Bible for now?”

“A Bible?”

“What’s that?”

“The history of this land. The word of God. Think of it along those lines.”

“Oh! Ohhh!”

“Truly, a talent sent by the gods!”

After that, I tossed out a few hints and watched from the sidelines.

They started racking their brains for lore like webnovel authors with a deadline breathing down their necks.

Then the traitors who had spent the past ten days locked in the underground prison were finally dragged before everyone.

“P-please spare me!”

“Baeksang tricked me! I never joined forces with Dark Heaven!”

But there was no forgiveness. No mercy.

Ssshhhhhh.

The benevolent Earth Mother Goddess’s blessing fell upon the land.

Beneath the rain—by then known as the Sacred Rain—the people cried out for judgment, and the executioner’s blade flashed.

Slash!

That was the end of it. The bodies of the traitors who had once led this land were thrown to the beasts.

The rain fell without end, washing away the blood they had spilled.

And only then did the people suddenly realize.

They had finally become one.

They had overcome a catastrophe together, witnessed and experienced an unbelievable miracle, and at last become one family within the warm embrace of the Earth Mother Goddess.

That was the true miracle.

A miracle that had finally united the people of thirty-two tribes.

And the forest keeper who had cut down every diseased tree and weed in the forest shouted before them all.

“From this moment on, we are the people of Nanman—wholly united as one!”

“Waaaaaah!”

Their voices rose together, echoing in every direction.

It sounded like the roar of warriors heralding the Great War soon to come.

Chapter 723

One day. Two days. Then three.

The rain that had come to be called the Sacred Rain still fell across Nanman. Beneath the benevolent grace of the Earth Mother Goddess, nothing could stop its newly united people.

Thud! Craaack!

With a single swing of an ax from an older man, a massive tree snapped, while a thin woman casually hoisted a mountain of firewood.

Watching from the window, I muttered, “Wow. They got one hell of a buff.”

“A b-buff?”

The question came from behind me. I already knew I had a visitor, so I turned to answer.

“Nothing. What brings you here? Shouldn’t you be swamped right now?”

“I was passing by. Besides, I’m not as busy as I was. Everything is being put right in the blink of an eye.”

“Really?”

For an uninvited guest, Yayul Mok was a welcome sight. I looked at the Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace and went on.

“That’s good news. Who do they have to thank?”

Yayul Mok shrugged.

“Father says it’s thanks to some Han Chinese man. He must be mistaken.”

“I don’t think he is.”

“He must be. A despicable Han Chinese man would never help us.”

“True. You can’t trust anyone from the Central Plains.”

“Now you’re speaking sense.”

A brief silence passed. Then, as if on cue, we both let out a quiet laugh.

“It’s all thanks to you, Jin Taekyung.”

“We all worked hard, but that’s true. I did contribute quite a lot.”

The smile on Yayul Mok’s face deepened at my shameless reply.

“Are all Han Chinese as lacking in humility as you?”

“No. Just me.”

“That’s a relief.”

“Why?”

“Because I think I could grow to like Han Chinese more than I do now.”

“Oh…”

I looked at him with fresh eyes.

I never thought I'd hear him say that. I'd noticed the change little by little, but the hostility toward the Central Plains that once filled him was gone.

"Don't like them too much. Go there and you'll find plenty of madmen."

"You take me for a child. I know people are much the same wherever you go. In Nanman and the Central Plains alike."

"Really? You didn't seem to know that when we first met."

"…That was because you turned the fields into a sea of fire."

Looking a little embarrassed by the memory, Yayul Mok came over to the window. He gazed out through its half-open shutters, then spoke.

"It still doesn't feel real. That all this could happen in the place where I was born and raised."

"The disaster? Or the miracle?"

"Both." After a moment, he added, "But this, too, must be a god's will."

"…You believe in the Earth Mother Goddess too?"

"I don't know about that. But I believe a god exists. I've seen things I can't explain any other way."

Anyone who encounters something beyond understanding is bound to think of a god. You might not know who's up there in that impossibly distant sky, but you'd figure they must be someone impressive.

I'm no different.

I kept that last thought to myself and changed the subject.

"So, how's the cleanup going?"

"If you mean the restoration, we're already in the final stages. We should see the finished results within a few days at the latest."

Considering that the Inner Palace had been reduced to a wasteland and more than several hundred houses and pavilions in the Outer Palace had collapsed, it was a truly astonishing pace.

But instead of being surprised, I gave a small nod.

Well, that buff is incredible.

The rain falling even now carried the powers of life and purification. It was an area-wide buff that kept people full of energy and enhanced their physical abilities.

It'll wear off when the rain stops, of course. But a few days is plenty.

They say even a sheet of paper is easier to lift when two people do it together. Here, tens of thousands of Nanman people were working day and night to rebuild their homes, to make a new start in the place where they belonged.

And their efforts were bearing fruit at an incredible pace.

"What about the other matter?"

Yayul Mok understood what I meant.

“We abolished the Great Chieftain system to remove the hierarchy and divisions that remained between the tribes. The Miao people and all four of the other major tribes agreed.”

“Good. Oh, what about Yohi?”

He nodded.

“She was the first to propose abolishing it.”

The tribal chieftains who had joined hands with Baeksang had been executed in front of countless witnesses, but Yohi alone had received a full pardon.

She had repented of her wrongdoing, however late. More importantly, she had led the beasts in helping the tribespeople escape the Outer Palace. No one had raised any real objection to her pardon.

“She said that she couldn’t leave behind the same precedent as Baeksang, Heugung, and herself.”

“She’s right. The Great Chieftains had too much power.”

“Father and the other tribal chieftains agreed. From now on, the Nanman Beast Palace will answer to the Palace Lord alone. The Tribal Grand Council will remain in case of an emergency. And…”

As I listened to the rest of Yayul Mok’s explanation, I realized once again that the Nanman Beast Palace had been reborn.

The Beast Miao King was now both Palace Lord and priest, with authority far greater than before. The appearance of the Earth Mother Goddess had calmed the people, and they had come together regardless of tribe or faith.

For hundreds of years, since the founding of the Nanman Beast Palace, this land had been divided into thirty-two pieces. At last, it was united.

You really could call it a small kingdom now.

Its tribespeople numbered in the tens of thousands, and its warriors nearly ten thousand. With the beasts they commanded as well, calling it a kingdom was no exaggeration.

Even allowing for the fact that the Nanman warriors were inferior to the martial arts of the Central Plains, they still represented an immense military force.

I looked at Yayul Mok with fresh interest.

“…Why are you looking at me like that?”

“Now that I think about it, you do look kind of noble. Turns out you’re a prince, or something.”

“…A prince?”

He repeated the word doubtfully, then let out a quiet laugh.

“What’s so funny? It’s not that far off.”

“I was just thinking what an honor it is.”

“What?”

“To be called a prince by the Apostle of the great Earth Mother Goddess. What else would you call it?”

“…?”

What was he talking about?

While I blinked at him, Yayul Mok took something from inside his robe and held it out.

“Take it.”

This is…

“We decided to call it the Mother Goddess Scripture. Father asked me to give it to you.”

I took the bundle of bamboo strips, still bewildered.

Ding.

SYSTEM

— You have acquired Mother Goddess Scripture.
— Mother Goddess Scripture is a scripture containing records of the Earth Mother Goddess.
— A god can exist only when someone believes in it.
— The Earth Mother Goddess has become known as the One God of Nanman!
— Countless believers who follow the Earth Mother Goddess are ecstatic!
— According to the records in Mother Goddess Scripture, your name has become known anew!
— You have achieved Religious Reformation, an achievement that makes one wonder whether anyone would actually go this far!
— You have acquired the Title Apostle of the Earth Mother Goddess!

Holographic windows filled the air along with the System notifications.

I stared at them for a moment, then hurriedly unrolled the bamboo strips. After reading the tiny writing on them, I burst out laughing in disbelief.

“What is this?”

Seeing my reaction, Yayul Mok shrugged.

“It says exactly what it means. The Earth Mother Goddess has been with this land since ancient times as its mother goddess, and whenever Nanman fell into crisis, she personally sent her apostle to save the people…”

“And that’s me?”

"Of course. Three hundred years ago, it was my ancestor, the first Palace Lord. And two hundred years ago, it was the Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan at the time—the clan you belong to."

They'd managed to fit it all together.

Sure, I'd given them a few hints. I just hadn't expected to find my name written out in full.

No, not just *my* name. *Our* names.

Rustle.

I skimmed the rest and found plenty I recognized. Jeok Cheongang, of course. The Fire Dragon Pavilion members. Even Namho.

This was supposed to be something like a Bible. Could they really put us all in it?

"I know it was thrown together in a hurry, but this is ridiculous. Who the hell came up with this setting?"

"My father."

"No wonder it's so impressive. How did he manage to make the setting this detailed?"

"…"

I avoided Yayul Mok's gaze and tucked the bamboo strips into my robe.

The Apostle of the Earth Mother Goddess.

I'd somehow become an apostle of a god, a role that certainly hadn't been written in my fate. But I didn't feel bad about it. In fact, right now it was a major gain.

It should ease some of the resentment Nanman's people hold toward the Central Plains.

Yayul Mok suddenly spoke, interrupting my thoughts.

"So, are you ready?"

"Hm?"

"To leave Nanman."

"…!"

After a moment's silence, I smacked my lips.

"You're sharp."

"It would be strange if I hadn't noticed."

"How did you find out?"

"Even if I ignored everyone else, that huge fellow has been frantically gathering food since yesterday. As if he's preparing for a long journey."

There was no need to ask who he meant by "that huge fellow." Guessing the culprit, I sighed.

"Taishan, you crazy bastard. I told you to move quietly."

"Your master, Fire King Jeok Cheongang, made off with five jars of fruit wine."

"…"

Oh, come on, Old Master.

I squeezed my eyes shut. Yayul Mok's voice reached me anyway.

"You should at least say goodbye before you go. Everyone's waiting."

It wasn't until we neared the North Gate that I realized Yayul Mok hadn't been exaggerating when he said *everyone*.

This is…

Thousands of people. Maybe tens of thousands.

Among the countless people filling the field outside the North Gate, where fresh grass and flowers had spread thanks to the life-giving downpour, I saw several familiar faces.

Jeok Cheongang stood in front of a cart loaded with jars of fruit wine, pretending nothing was out of the ordinary.

Taishan held meat in both hands, looking solemn. Beside him were the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, each mounted on a beast.

And then…

"You've finally arrived."

Yayul Cheok, the Beast Miao King and master of the Nanman Beast Palace, spoke with a stern face. He stood here on behalf of everyone in this land.

"Why were you going to leave without a word?"

I scratched the back of my head.

"I was going to tell you."

"You were?"

"Well… in a letter."

"Just a letter?"

"You looked so busy…"

"Do you think that makes sense?"

"…"

Was this what they called a question-mark murderer?

I couldn't find an answer. The Beast Miao King, a full head taller than me, gazed down at me.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung."

It was a quiet summons. The Beast Miao King continued in a solemn voice.

"You came to our homeland for a reason. You had a purpose here, did you not?"

"…"

“And now you mean to leave without a word, though you have not achieved that purpose. You faced death countless times in an unfamiliar land and saved countless lives. Yet not once did you ask for the reward you were owed.”

His gaze and voice were fixed on me, but everyone gathered there could hear him. Everyone was watching.

“Why?”

I found myself answering.

“I was just one person trying to save other people.”

“…!”

“I didn’t do it for a reward. And I couldn’t ask anyone to make another sacrifice. That’s why I was going to leave.”

Silence fell.

Tens of thousands of people stood together, yet I couldn’t hear a single breath. Against that silence, the rain falling on our heads sounded louder than ever. Beyond it, the Beast Miao King’s towering figure moved.

Rustle.

His back was as firm as a pillar—the back of the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, a man who should never have had to bow to anyone. Now it bent toward me.

Before all his people, he offered me a deeply respectful clasped-fist bow.

“I, Yayul Cheok, the Beast Miao King, on behalf of everyone who lives on this land, formally petition Great Hero Jin Taekyung, Fire Dragon Pavilion Master, for our admission into the Murim Alliance.”

It happened on a day when the rain was slowly easing.

Chapter 724

Some people left. Others stayed behind.

As the Beast Miao King watched the travelers disappear into the distance, he knew they would meet again before the ache of this farewell had faded.

And when they did, it would be on a battlefield, fighting back-to-back.

“In the end, we’re going to the Central Plains once again.”

The Beast Miao King gave a small nod at the voice beside him.

“Yes. So it has come to this.”

“A great deal of blood will be spilled.”

“Do you think your father made the wrong decision?”

“No.”

Yayul Mok continued calmly.

“If my father—no, if the Palace Lord hadn’t wanted to go to the Central Plains, I would have gone with them on my own.”

“…!”

His gaze followed the figures receding in the distance.

Strangers from a foreign land. Yet it was because those strangers had come that they had been able to protect their homeland.

“Now it’s our turn to help them.”

There had been a time when Yayul Mok, too, had been hostile to the Central Plains and rejected the Han Chinese.

But things were different now. The still-unseasoned Young Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace had learned what it meant to act with humanity from one stranger. He would never forget the conversation they had shared.

“What would you do if the pasture caught fire?”

“Put it out right away.”

“Why?”

“Because if we don’t, the flames will spread everywhere.”

“Good. There’s your answer.”

“…!”

“Don’t overthink why we came. There’s a fire, so we’re trying to put it out. Just like the Nanman people who left this land for the Central Plains decades ago.”

At first, he hadn’t believed it. He couldn’t.

The Han Chinese he knew were despicable people who had betrayed Nanman’s trust and driven countless of its people to their deaths.

[3031] Using the Chinese *li*, ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,110 mi).

There was no way they had traveled more than ten thousand li[3031] to help without asking for anything in return.

That was what he had thought then.

But now I understand what you meant.

The pasture called the world was already on fire, and the vast inferno known as Dark Heaven would devour everything.

Where people were born and raised, how they dressed, what they looked like—none of it mattered now.

Just as Nanman had finally become one, everyone would have to join forces to put out the fire.

“We’ll fight with our lives on the line. For everyone who lives on this land. And for them.”

At the sight of his son’s resolve, the Beast Miao King smiled faintly.

When did he grow up so much?

Just as Nanman had finally become one, his only son had grown as well.

So why did the Beast Miao King’s heart feel as hollow as an empty jar?

You hopeless fool.

He swallowed the bitter thought and tilted a flask he had taken from his robes.

Fragrant fruit wine fell with the dwindling rain and soaked into the earth—the soil of the homeland where two sworn brothers had been born and raised together.

“Good wine, this. Wouldn’t you agree?”

The Beast Miao King had not tasted a drop, yet at his mumble the people around him looked puzzled. He merely laughed with relief.

This was enough.

One distant day, they would meet again and raise their cups together.

Yes. Someday, without fail.

The Beast Miao King lifted his head. Through the thinning rain, azure heaven spread above the countless people of Nanman.

Or perhaps it was the gaze of an unseen absolute being.

“Sound the war drums.”

His low voice broke the suffocating silence. He drew a deep breath, gathered his internal energy, and shouted.

“God wills it!”

His azure dragon’s roar rang in every direction. Somewhere high on a hill, the snow-white White Tiger that had been watching them let out a roar of its own.

Kraaaaaaang!

Clang-clang-clang!

“Waaaaaaah!”

Thousands—tens of thousands—of beasts and humans stamped their feet and cried out. Sunlight flashed from countless blades, scattering in every direction.

At long last, the prelude to the Great War had begun.

A melancholy look in his eyes, Hyuk Mujin waited until everyone was watching before slowly opening his mouth.

“I was just one person trying to save other people.”

“Stop.”

“I didn’t do it for a reward. And I couldn’t ask anyone to make another sacrifice. That’s why I was going to leave.”

“I said stop.”

“Come on, why are you like this? I never get tired of doing this, no matter how many times I repeat it. Honestly, you all agree, don’t you?”

Taishan, who was tearing into a wild boar’s hind leg atop a bear running at full speed, nodded vigorously.

“Taishan agrees!”

“See? Even he agrees. I was just one person trying to save—”

I quietly cut Hyuk Mujin off.

“Mujin.”

“Yes.”

“Do you want to become a eunuch?”

The grin vanished from his face.

“No.”

“Is your life too boring, then?”

“Not at all. I’m worried it’s already more exciting than I can handle.”

“Want me to make it peaceful?”

“You don’t mean that you’re going to kill me, do you?”

“What if I do?”

“Wow, look over there. Beautiful scenery.”

“Good. Let’s travel quietly.”

“…Yes, sir.”

Hyuk Mujin shut his mouth, but Taishan looked disappointed and called for an encore.

“Pavilion Master! Taishan wants to hear more!”

So I called in his designated bully.

“Old Man Nam, I think it’s time to shut that bastard’s mouth.”

“Oh, finally!”

Namho cheered like an independence fighter at liberation[3032] and pulled a muzzle from his robes as though he'd been waiting for the signal.

Made of sturdy black iron and leather straps, it looked bizarre—and strangely familiar.

"Wait. Where did you get that?"

"From a Nanman animal trainer. He said they mostly use it to tame wild bears."

"…"

"Why are you looking at me like that? Is there a problem?"

"Well, not exactly."

Something about it bothered me. I had the uneasy feeling that if Namho put it on him, I'd have to stop calling him Taishan and start calling him product number TAESAN-317.

I hesitated, then gave in and sighed.

"Don't put it on him. Actually, just throw it away."

"No! Why?"

Why? Because I felt like it would dirty my eyes.

I snatched the muzzle from the practically wailing Namho and hurled it into the distance. Jeok Cheongang, who had watched the whole thing, spoke with an uneasy look on his face.

"What on earth happened in Nanman?"

For a moment, I didn't understand what he meant.

"Pardon?"

"I'm asking what happened to make every last one of you lose your mind."

"A lot happened in Nanman, sure, but they were all like this to begin with."

"What?"

"Surprising, but true."

"You brat! Don't talk nonsense. With things this much of a goddamn mess, how did none of you get killed?"

"…"

Yeah. Fuck.

Looking back on what had happened in Nanman, I had a reasonable suspicion that the Earth Mother Goddess really had blessed us.

I came close to death several times. Making it back in one piece is a miracle.

Of course, I was the only one who had come close to death that many times. The others had suffered injuries, major and minor, but the Sacred Rain had worked so well that every one of them had recovered completely.

And we somehow stopped Dark Heaven's plot.

[3032] "Liberation" refers to Korea's liberation from Japanese colonial rule in 1945.

A great many people had died in the process. Still, stopping the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—practically the Fire Dragon Pavilion's top priority, and mine—was more than half a success.

The Nanman Beast Palace officially joined the Murim Alliance, too.

Truthfully, that had been all but certain once we stopped the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. Even without the Earth Mother Goddess's value as a new brand, the outcome probably wouldn't have changed much.

Stamp out a fire halfheartedly and it only burns hotter. Anger can draw scattered people together.

All I had done was give them another point to rally around: a One God who could erase boundaries between tribes that had stood for centuries and help them become a more united, more powerful force.

And that made the Murim Alliance stronger, too.

On this, I had no doubts. The Nanman Beast Palace was firmly on our side now.

According to what the Beast Miao King had promised before we left, they would send more troops than they had during the Great Faction War and do everything in their power to hold back Dark Heaven.

So why?

Why do I still feel uneasy?

We'd accomplished a great deal, yet I couldn't shake the feeling that something was wrong.

Perhaps it was because one question remained unanswered.

The new Murim Alliance has been formed. The forces of the Central Plains are gathering around the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families. Yet Dark Heaven still hasn't shown its full strength.

Their first intervention in Shanxi Province, the Shaolin Bloodshed that followed, and every incident since—none of them had been minor. But each had involved only a fragment of Dark Heaven, not the organization as a whole.

They should be past the point of testing the waters.

What the hell were they—or rather, what was the Lord of Heaven—trying to do?

And why did the Lord of Heaven…

"Why would the Lord of Heaven take this much interest in me, of all people?"

I hadn't meant to say it aloud. Everyone looked at me at once, and before I could explain, Hyuk Mujin perked up like a meerkat.

"Gasp, Captain. Did someone confess to you? Oh my God. A Nanman?"

"…"

I wanted to gouge out his eyes, sparkling like the morning star. I fought the urge.

"It's not like that, you crazy bastard."

"Then she's Han Chinese?"

“How many times do I have to tell you—wait. Come to think of it, that part’s right.”

“Wow. When did this happen? Who confessed?”

“The Lord of Heaven.”

“Now there’s an impressive name for a young lady. Sounds like a daughter from a respectable family…”

Hyuk Mujin stopped. He blinked, thought for a moment, then spoke again.

“Who?”

“The Lord of Heaven.”

“The one I know? I mean, the one *everyone* knows?”

“Who else?”

“Fuck. That respectable household was in Xinjiang…”

Beyond Qinghai, where the Kunlun Sect stood, lay Xinjiang. For a thousand years, Xinjiang had been the domain of the Demonic Path.

Once everyone realized that the supposed young lady interested in me belonged to Dark Heaven’s household, they stared at one another, momentarily lost for words. Then the questions came all at once.

“Why would the Lord of Heaven be interested in you?” Hyuk Mujin asked.

Namho cut in. “Isn’t it obvious? He keeps getting in the Lord of Heaven’s way.”

“Sure, but the Captain isn’t one of the Three Saints or the Ten Kings. He’s just a scrap who’s only just made a name for himself.”

“Now that you mention it, you’re not wrong.”

“Taishan can eat scraps.”

“You son of a bitch. I knew this might happen, so I brought another muzzle. Come here. Open your mouth.”

“Why are you all talking about him like that? Our Pavilion Master is a scrap? Song Escort, Sama Pyo! Say something!”

“Young Lady Ju, I’m sorry, but I think I have to leave. I managed to make it all the way to Nanman, but if the Lord of Heaven has taken an interest in that man…”

“Taishan! That’s not meat! Don’t bite it! Old Man Nam, put that muzzle down!”

“…”

Fuck. I had never seen such a complete mess.

I stared blankly at the disaster unfolding before me. Then a quiet Sound Transmission reached my ears.

—Let’s talk.

It was Jeok Cheongang.

Chapter 725

“Let’s talk.”

I gave a small nod at the Sound Transmission in my ear and loosened my grip on the reins.

The beast understood and gradually slowed. Jeok Cheongang drew alongside me, then spoke.

“Is it true the Lord of Heaven has taken a particular interest in you?”

“Yes.”

“Huh. Strange. This old man is hearing about it for the first time.”

“I suppose so. It’s the first time I’ve mentioned it, too.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

“You never asked.”

Honestly, I expected to get hit for that. I even snapped into a defensive stance.

But Jeok Cheongang only stared at me for a moment before muttering, almost to himself, “You didn’t tell me because I didn’t ask… Well, I can’t say you’re wrong.”

What had gotten into him?

“Um, Old Master?”

“What.”

“Are you… sulking?”

“What? Sulking? Me?”

“Yes.”

Jeok Cheongang laughed as though I’d told him a marvelous joke.

“Why would I sulk? I’m not five years old. Of course, we had plenty of time to discuss it over the past three days, and I held back from asking out of consideration for you. But that doesn’t matter in the slightest, so don’t give it another thought. The fool is the one who didn’t ask, isn’t he? Hahaha.”

“…”

“People in the martial world say a master and disciple should keep no secrets from each other. But that hardly applies to us, so pay it no mind. If you think about it, I needed someone to carry on the Fire Gate Clan’s lineage, and you needed martial arts. We both got what we wanted. That’s enough. Talking about the bond between master and disciple in this day and age is laughable anyway.”

“…”

“I ran my balls off getting to Nanman because I was worried something might happen to you. Even plucked out every hair on my perfectly good head to hide my identity. But I’m fine. My balls didn’t fall off, and my hair will grow back soon enough. Of course it will.”

“…”

"Why would this old man sulk just because he didn't hear some goddamn story? A thirsty man should dig his own well. If I waited for you to tell me when the time was right, wouldn't I end up dried out and dead just like this old man? Hahahaha."

Watching Jeok Cheongang laugh like an immortal, I thought, *He's really fucking sulking.*

Could a person even sulk this much?

Forbes could name him the World's Most Sulky Person, and no one would object.

"I remember the day I first met you. I wasn't in my right mind then, what with the infirmities of old age. I suppose that's why they say old people ought to die…"

The pressure was suffocating.

I finally managed to interrupt Jeok Cheongang's runaway train of a speech.

"What I said earlier was a joke. I had too much on my mind to tell you. I needed time to sort through it myself."

"Hm."

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes. Sounding a little more like himself, he asked gruffly, "So was the part about the Lord of Heaven a joke too?"

"Unfortunately, that part's true."

"What proof do you have?"

I told him what had happened. He'd already heard a brief version while we were at the Nanman Beast Palace, but this time I went into far more detail.

By the time I finished, his brow was furrowed.

"Those bastards tried to capture you?"

"Yes. But when that didn't work, they tried to kill me. The Great Snow Fiend and Black Hand Fist Demon at the Poisonblood Grounds, and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress too."

"Did they try to capture you on the Lord of Heaven's orders?"

"That…"

I thought back for a moment, then shook my head.

"I don't think so."

"Why not?"

"If the Lord of Heaven had ordered her to capture me, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress wouldn't have tried to kill me. Not even if she had to face her own death alone."

"Loyalty that outweighs her life… Hard to believe."

"It wasn't just loyalty."

I answered quietly as I recalled everything about the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. The look in her eyes. Her expression. The rapture in her voice, and all she had said and done.

What I'd sensed from her that day couldn't be described as mere loyalty.

It was…

“Fanaticism. To the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—no, to Dark Heaven—the Lord of Heaven is a living god.”

“…!”

“Everyone in Dark Heaven fears and reveres him. If he ordered them to capture me at any cost, that would be a divine command no one could defy.”

The Blood Lord, for all his power. The Western Heaven Demon Lord. Even the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, who had now met her end.

All of them had bowed before the Lord of Heaven and called themselves his servants.

Each was a monster capable of tearing an ordinary Supreme Peak master apart with their bare hands. And the Lord of Heaven was the king—the god—those monsters worshiped.

“I can’t be certain, but I think the Southern Heaven Demon Empress tried to capture me simply because the Lord of Heaven had shown an interest in me.”

“To win his favor?”

I nodded. Jeok Cheongang let out a low groan.

“Fanatics…”

The word faded into the wind.

Seated on the tiger’s back, he watched the scenery rush past in silence. Then he spoke again.

“Have you ever seen a member of the Demonic Cult?”

“Do I look sixty to you?”

“Yes. At your age, it would be natural that you hadn’t seen one. You were born long after the Great Faction War ended.”

“Then why ask?”

“A thought occurred to me. We might be better off fighting the Demonic Cult of those days all over again.”

“…!”

“They were fanatics too, of course. But their leader, the Heavenly Demon, was still a man. The hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path beneath him knew it. To them, he was the Cult Leader who led them. He was not a god.”

I understood what Jeok Cheongang meant.

To the Demonic Cult, the Heavenly Demon had been flesh and blood. To Dark Heaven, the Lord of Heaven was a god.

They would fight for that god without fear of death. They would die smiling, even with countless spears and blades buried in their bodies.

“This will be a more terrible war than any we’ve known.”

Jeok Cheongang fixed me with a grave look.

"Especially for you."

"Because the Lord of Heaven is watching me?"

"Whether you wanted it or not, you've drawn more attention than you should have. Somewhere in the world, even now, people are speaking your name."

"…"

"The Three Saints and Ten Kings are old names. But you are different. You possess a talent without precedent throughout history, and no one in the world can deny that you became a master despite having only just passed the age of twenty."

His gaze held unmistakable pride—and worry.

"That is why the Lord of Heaven is watching you, too. And more importantly, he has already seen you once—your true nature and the infinite potential hidden within you."

"…The Sichuan Tang Clan's underground prison."

"Yes. He used some unknown supernatural power to look at you through the Western Heaven Demon Lord's eyes."

How could I forget?

Stone dust raining onto my head. Blood spattered across the stone wall.

And the words of the Western Heaven Demon Lord, standing there as he looked at me.

No. The words of the Lord of Heaven, who had borrowed his servant's body for a moment.

Interesting. Very interesting.

He had been smiling then. Even as his entire body turned into a handful of ashes and scattered away, he had not forgotten to offer me one final greeting.

I'll see you again.

The memory still made my heart sink.

Jeok Cheongang watched me draw a slow breath, then said, "Perhaps… the Lord of Heaven has some inkling of the secrets you've never told anyone."

"…!"

"That's why I can no longer avoid asking."

The world seemed to stop, as though someone had pressed pause. Jeok Cheongang spoke slowly.

"Can you tell this old man everything you've been hiding?"

Jeok Cheongang raised his head to the sky.

After three days of unbroken rain, it was blue and clear—nothing like the turmoil in his mind.

The realm of immortals…

The words he could not bring himself to say faded within him. What else was there to say? How was he supposed to make sense of it?

He had lived a long life. Suddenly, all those years felt of no use at all.

If you were here, I could have steadied this confused heart in no time.

He thought of the friend who had died several months ago. A monk who loved drink and meat and scarcely behaved like a monk at all, yet had been called the Dharma King because he cared more deeply for people than anyone.

Then Jeok Cheongang shook his head.

The Dharma King was gone. And even if he were alive, he could no longer look up at that blue sky and read its heavenly patterns.

You said the heavenly patterns had already gone awry. That the sky no longer gave anyone any answers. You definitely said that.

The Dharma King had also foretold a great war. A force that would throw even the heavens into turmoil would spread across the world, then sweep through it like fire.

But his prediction had not ended there.

The Master of the Morning Star.

A new star rising to light the troubled heavens.

The Dharma King had identified a young man as the Master of that Morning Star, and afterward Jeok Cheongang had gone to Mount Jiuhua and made that young man the successor to the Fire Gate Clan's lineage.

"…Hah. And I thought you were just a monk who liked talking nonsense."

His hollow chuckle vanished into the air. He let the cool wind wash over him, then glanced to his side.

A beast raced onward. Strapped securely to its saddle with sturdy leather, a young man lay facedown, fast asleep.

No. Not just any young man.

His one and only Disciple.

What an infuriating brat. He caused all this trouble, and now he's sleeping like a baby.

It was absurd. But after hearing Jin Taekyung's account, Jeok Cheongang had no strength left to be surprised.

Another world, wholly separate from Murim. And a young man who traveled between Murim and that place, which sounded so much like the realm of immortals.

What an infuriating brat. He caused all this trouble, and now he's sleeping like a baby.

It was absurd. But after hearing Jin Taekyung's account, Jeok Cheongang had no strength left to be surprised.

Another world, wholly separate from Murim. And a young man who traveled between Murim and that place, which sounded so much like the realm of immortals.

He could not understand it all. Still, he had accepted that every word of the unbelievable story was true.

Could this brat be a Little Immortal?

Just then, a long strand of drool hanging from Jin Taekyung's mouth landed squarely on his cheek.

Splat.

"…"

Jeok Cheongang's fist tightened on its own.

But instead of rapping his sleeping Disciple on the forehead, he sighed and straightened the young man's posture.

Yes. Sleep soundly. You've been through a lot.

No. That wasn't quite right.

In a voice soft enough for only one person to hear, Jeok Cheongang murmured, "Go on. Come back safely."

Chapter 726

> **System** - **Synchronization** begins. - 10, 9, 8, 7, 6… - **Logout** complete.

I opened my eyes to a familiar chime. The first thing I saw was a ceiling impossibly far above me.

Not the wooden ceiling that smelled of old, dry grass, but a pristine white one made of solid alloy.

I still wasn't used to the jarring shift between worlds. As I lay there, I recalled my last memory of the modern world.

The training room.

Right. This was the Peace Guild's training room. Only a handful of people, myself included, were allowed inside. Protected by formidable security and surveillance systems, it was where I had left for Murim—right after finally taking care of an important matter I had put off for a long time.

That's right.

I stared at the ceiling in silence.

My memories of my time in Murim had returned, along with all my senses, but I had no desire whatsoever to get up.

Murim to the modern world. The modern world to Murim.

A spell of listlessness after crossing between the two wasn't unusual for me. This time, though, it hit especially hard.

…I really went and did it.

I'd imagined telling someone my secret dozens of times. Of course, I'd never actually done it. I couldn't have.

It was too dangerous.

But… it was also true that, somewhere in the back of my mind, I had thought that a day like this would come eventually. I just hadn't expected that day, which had seemed so far away, to be today.

What did you say?

I could still see Jeok Cheongang's reaction when he first heard my confession. He hadn't looked shocked or incredulous. No, he simply hadn't understood what I was saying.

"What did you just say?"

"Exactly what I said. I came from farther away than you think, Old Master."

"Shanxi Province is some distance from the Central Plains, yes. But what does that have to do with your secret…?"

"Farther than that. Farther than Nanman, even."

"Farther than Nanman?"

“Yes. So far you couldn’t reach it if you walked your entire life.”

“You mean you have to take a boat?”

“No. That’s not it. I mean… it’s a completely different world.”

A completely different world.

Jeok Cheongang listened to what came next, then fell silent for a long time, trying to make sense of it in his own way.

“So you’re saying you came from the realm of immortals.”

“…Uh. I guess you could put it that way.”

“Are you a Little Immortal?”

“I’m an ordinary citizen.”

If Jeok Cheongang had been from the modern world, we might have understood each other a little better. In a world that already had monsters and magic, one man from Murim wouldn’t have been impossible to comprehend.

Whether that man wound up in a psychiatric hospital or got dragged off to a laboratory afterward was another question.

But Jeok Cheongang had spent over a hundred years in Murim, a world without even the internet. Everything I told him was bound to sound bewildering.

“When you fall asleep here, you go to the realm of immortals?”

“Not every time, but unless something unusual happens, yes.”

“And when you wish to leave the realm of immortals and return here…”

“It works the same way. Each time, time in the other world moves very slowly.”

“…Goddamn it.”

After a desperate struggle to hold on to his common sense and reason, Jeok Cheongang finally reached a conclusion.

“Damn it. I don’t understand.”

“What?”

“I’m telling you, I still don’t understand.”

Some truths couldn’t be understood even if you saw them with your own eyes and heard them with your own ears. Everything I’d told Jeok Cheongang was like that for him.

Yet amid all his confusion, one thing remained unchanged.

“But the idiot standing before this old man is named Jin Taekyung. Not a Little Immortal descended from the realm of immortals. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

“…!”

“That alone is enough.”

I hadn’t understood then why those words left me speechless. Why I had to clench my teeth against the heat rising in my chest.

But… yes. As Jeok Cheongang had said, that alone was enough for me, too.

And now I thought I understood why.

I'd been afraid. Afraid that the other world, now such a large part of my life, might deny that I belonged there.

What am I, a little kid?

A rueful laugh slipped out. At the same time, the weight pressing on my heart lifted, and I felt relieved.

Right. This is enough. For now, at least.

Since when had I ever lived with my eyes fixed on the future? I'd chosen where to go one day, one moment at a time, and that had brought me here.

The path I'd chosen today was as wide and warm as a beach in summer.

I'd seen on TV that athletes all had their own routines.

One soccer player always stepped onto the field with his left foot first. A star Major League batter spat out a sunflower seed every time he swung his bat.

To an ordinary person, that might seem like an awful lot of fuss over nothing. But everyone had little superstitions for peace of mind and good luck.

No profession took them more seriously than Hunters.

Lose a soccer game, and the sky doesn't fall. Strike out on three pitches with the bases loaded and a chance to take the lead, and the ground doesn't open beneath you.

A Hunter, though, could be dead the moment luck turned bad.

There was no next game. No next at-bat. Just their life and their family's faces flashing through their mind as they drew their final breath, and one sudden thought:

Fuck, I should've worn my blue underwear today.

It sounded like a joke, but it was true. Those had been the last words of an A-rank Hunter who'd died in a Gate a few years ago, at the height of his popularity.

Or was it red underwear?

I'd been working nonstop back then, so the details were hazy. Anyway.

The point was, I had a routine of my own. I'd followed it without fail until now, and it had just been broken.

Bang!

The door flew open as if something had exploded.

The lock I had installed as a precaution was destroyed. Fortunately, I had finished all my preparations one step ahead of time, so I did my best to remain calm as I welcomed the unwelcome guest.

"Well, well. You don't even knock anymore before barging in."

"Huff. Hah."

He was breathing hard, sweat beading on his forehead, his suit in disarray. I looked at him and added, “Team Leader Choi.”

Normally, I’d have been glad to see him. Right now, I wanted to punch that handsome face.

But Team Leader Choi—who, by all rights, should now be called the Guild Master—didn’t notice my mood. Or rather, he had no attention to spare for it.

“Huff. Hoo.”

What, was the Demon King chasing him?

These days, Team Leader Choi could hold his own against any Peak Master in the Central Plains. He finally caught his breath, thrust out what he was holding, and shouted, “What is this? What on earth is this?”

“If you don’t have anything important to say, come back a little later… Ah. That?”

“*That?* Is this something you can dismiss with ‘that’?”

Rage button: ON.

The way he nearly lost his mind over my casual answer told me two things. First, I was going to have to break the essential routine I’d followed every day since finishing Hunter training. Second, there was no getting out of explaining that *thing* right now.

“Calm down. Calm down. I’ll tell you everything, so put that down first. Oh, and what would you like to drink?”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung. What you drink isn’t important right n—”

“I’ll just make you coffee. What was it again? That tiger-poop coffee you gave me last time to celebrate the opening of the office.”

“Hah.”

“That okay?”

Team Leader Choi stared at me, shock and disbelief mingling in his eyes, then sank onto the sofa.

In his trembling hand was a sheaf of papers covered in my own handwriting.

[The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method]

Looking at it again, my penmanship was a work of art.

Team Leader Choi really was a rich kid.

A moment ago, he’d been snorting like a Minotaur with its horns ripped out. One whiff of rich coffee, though, and he had his composure back. I couldn’t help sniffing the air myself.

“Does tiger-poop coffee calm you down or something? Or is this one of your routines?”

Team Leader Choi answered coolly. “It isn’t a tiger. It’s a cat. A civet cat.”

"Tiger, cat. Whatever."

"And rather than poop, please say feces. The word 'secretion' is also available."

"Poop."

"Feces. Or secretion."

"Right. So, poop."

"Unless you've forgotten, it will be dinnertime soon. If you keep saying 'poop' to someone's face like that…"

"Poop."

"…"

As the atmosphere grew increasingly shitty, Team Leader Choi was the first to back down.

"Fine. That isn't what matters right now."

"Mm."

On second thought, I was being an idiot. I took a breath and let go of my irritation. Team Leader Choi had broken a routine I absolutely needed to keep, but I was the one who'd given him the reason.

[The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method]

Anyone who saw this would have come running. Even the President of the United States.

"Given what's at stake, I'll ask you directly."

His voice trembled slightly. He looked me in the eye and went on.

"This… no, this mana cultivation method. Where did it come from?"

I answered without hesitation.

"Who do you think? The person sitting across from you."

"…!"

"I made it myself. From beginning to end."

A suffocating silence fell. Team Leader Choi stared at me, eyes wavering, before letting out the breath he'd been holding.

"Hoo."

"Why are you so surprised? Didn't the errand boy I sent explain?"

Of course, he wasn't just an errand boy. The Skeleton King might be a little unhinged, but he was a powerful Named Monster—and secretly operated as an S-rank Hunter for the Peace Guild.

More importantly, I could trust him.

Team Leader Choi knew that better than anyone. He gave a quiet laugh.

"That was quite an errand boy."

"That's why I entrusted it to him. I was originally going to give it to you myself, but you happened not to be there."

"…I had somewhere to stop by."

He left it at that, and I didn't ask where he'd been.

The person who had suddenly left us all two months ago had left a space that still held a lingering warmth, like the coffee cup before us that Team Leader Choi had not taken a single sip from.

"I heard what you told Skeleton King. No—Mr. King. But I'm sorry…"

"You had to check for yourself. I get it."

"Yes. But the moment I saw what was inside, even before hearing an explanation, I knew. Jin Taekyung is the only person in the entire world who could have created a mana cultivation method like this."

At his praise, I scratched the back of my head.

"Come on, it's not *that* impressive. I did put a lot of thought and effort into making it something even beginners could learn, but…"

"There can't be many S-rank Hunters with handwriting this bad. Or people with a sense for names like yours."

"What?"

"And someone who has both? I didn't need to think twice."

"…"

"That's how I knew this mana cultivation method could only have come from one person: Jin Taekyung."

"…"

I looked from Team Leader Choi's utterly certain face to **[The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method]** on the table, then back again.

What the fuck.

Mana cultivation method or not, maybe I should just tear the whole thing to shreds.

Chapter 727

Should I tear it up or not?

Looking at Jin Taekyung, whose thoughts were written plainly across his face, Choi Minwoo let out a faint, incredulous laugh inwardly.

I really can't figure him out.

Most of the time, his words, actions, and thoughts were as simple as could be. But every so often, Jin Taekyung showed a side of himself that went beyond surprising.

You'd think I'd be used to it by now. But this…

Choi Minwoo looked down at the table.

[The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method]

The crooked handwriting looked like a child's, and the title was ridiculous. But there was nothing ridiculous about what filled those ten or so sheets of A4 paper.

He created an entirely new Mana Cultivation Method.

There was a reason Choi Minwoo had gone so far as to criticize Jin Taekyung's handwriting earlier. It was a small act of revenge for suddenly handing over something this absurd without saying a word.

The shock he had felt a few hours ago had been that great.

How is this possible?

He had never seen explanations or instructions so simple and clear. The method was exceptionally stable, with a firm grounding in the fundamentals.

Choi Minwoo had grown skilled enough to hold his own against a Peak Master of Murim. He had recognized the value of this new method immediately. He had also understood what the recent events that had drawn the world's attention meant to Jin Taekyung.

"The Week of Judgment."

Choi Minwoo broke the brief silence and looked at Jin Taekyung.

"Just as God created heaven and earth over the course of a week, terrorists around the world endured a Week of Judgment. President Doramp Jr. said that at a White House press conference a few days ago."

The President of the United States had said it in public. Naturally, his provocative remarks had spread around the world in less than an hour. By now, everyone in Korea had heard about them.

Everyone but one person, perhaps.

"He said that?"

Jin Taekyung had been holed up in the training room the whole time. Choi Minwoo nodded.

“It was a fairly aggressive thing for any president to say, especially the American president. Some people criticized him for deliberately provoking the terrorists.”

“Hm. Why bring up something as grand as creating heaven and earth? What about retaliatory terrorism?”

“None. Not a single one.”

“Not one?”

“Yes. If anything, they’ve even been keeping their mouths shut.”

The sullen look on Jin Taekyung’s face eased a little.

“Guess beating the crap out of them paid off.”

It was at that exact moment that Choi Minwoo, who had been gazing pensively at Jin Taekyung, suddenly spoke.

“So that was why.”

“Why what?”

“I thought about two things. Why you suddenly suppressed the terrorists. And what it meant that you gave me this new Mana Cultivation Method.”

Now he had his answer.

[The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method]

Choi Minwoo lifted the papers, held together with a single careless staple.

“You’re planning to make this Mana Cultivation Method available to everyone.”

Jin Taekyung grinned.

“Our Team Leader Choi really is sharp.”

The look Team Leader Choi gave me was hard to read. Part of it seemed like admiration. The rest looked like he had a lot to think about.

“Why? Is there a problem?”

“Well…”

He ran a hand through his disheveled hair.

“There are so many problems, I don’t know where to start.”

“There’s nothing wrong with the Mana Cultivation Method itself, so you mean practical problems.”

“…Yes. Unfortunately.”

“What’s the biggest one?”

He thought for a moment.

“For starters, making the method public is a problem in its own right.”

“Go on.”

“You know that only a tiny fraction of high-ranking Hunters possess Mana Cultivation Methods. They’re closely guarded knowledge—secret arts, essentially.

You also know how closed-off those Hunters are, and how different their world is from the one other Hunters live in."

"I know. I've been in this business for years. Though back when I was an F-rank Hunter, I'd never even heard of a Mana Cultivation Method."

No profession divided its members more sharply than the Hunter business.

Ordinary people judged one another by education, family background, and looks. Hunters were sorted into high and low by Grade alone.

How much mana you'd been granted. How agile you were. How strong. Those crude measures determined your place, and you were graded like cattle headed for slaughter.

There's a reason they call F-rank Hunters slaves.

High-ranking Hunters, meanwhile, practically lived above the clouds. They earned more from a single raid than most Hunters could make in a lifetime and spent their days under spotlights and envious stares.

Maybe that was why they'd built walls around themselves, like nobles of old living inside their castles. No one but another high-ranking Hunter could cross those walls. Even if someone was lucky enough to receive a high Grade, the gate opened only with their permission.

Those high-ranking Hunters were connected by invisible ties across the world, each protected by the giant Guild they belonged to.

"This isn't limited to Korea," Team Leader Choi said. "If you make this method public, the backlash will be greater than you expect."

"Because they'll think releasing a Mana Cultivation Method makes what they have less valuable?"

"That's part of it. There's another reason."

"What?"

"The problem is that it's *us*."

"…!"

It was a short answer, but I immediately understood what he meant.

Have we stood out too much?

I suddenly remembered my conversation with Jeok Cheongang just before I logged out. Whether I had wanted it or not, he'd said, I had already drawn far more attention than necessary.

The spotlight was bright. But everything around it was dark.

I'd read that line in a novel I liked back in school. It was true. The brighter I became, the deeper the darkness around me grew.

In Murim and in the modern world.

"Team Leader Choi, by any chance…?"

He understood the question and shook his head.

“There’s been no major problem yet, but we’re facing pressure behind the scenes. We’ve put plans for more overseas branches on hold for now.”

“It’s that serious?”

“Every major Guild in the world is watching us. They don’t need to make a show of force to cause us trouble. If they decide to act, things won’t be easy for us.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

He gave me a flat look.

“Did you give me a chance?”

“…Fair.”

Still, this place was a complete mess too.

People with plenty to lose didn’t like the world changing. The handful of Hunters with Mana Cultivation Methods of their own were no exception.

At this point, calling them power brokers would be more accurate than calling them Hunters.

Some of them might have enough influence to bend an entire country to their will. With their wealth, fame, and overwhelming strength, they could turn common sense on its head. They didn’t want change, and they certainly didn’t want anyone new rising to their level.

Anyone like me or Team Leader Choi.

Even so, these bastards might be worse than Murim sects.

Leak a sect’s unique martial arts in Murim, and they’d hunt you down with murder in their eyes and smash your skull. But at least they wouldn’t throw a fit over a merchant selling the Three Calamities Sword Technique at a market.

These guys already had more than enough, and they were ready to raise hell because we wanted to share one little Mana Cultivation Method?

Huh. Now I’m pissed.

“If we release it, they’ll go nuts, right?”

“Yes. And we’ll have a mess on our hands.”

“What if I go after them?”

“What?”

“Now that I think about it, this is fucking ridiculous. We release the method without overthinking it, then I go after whichever assholes start trouble. That ought to shut them—”

“No! Don’t! Absolutely not!”

For Team Leader Choi’s normally low, composed voice to reach that volume, he might as well have said, *Over my dead body, you lunatic.*

This time, though, I couldn’t just give in.

“I know what you’re saying, Team Leader Choi, but we have to make it public. I didn’t create it to keep it to myself like a diary.”

Magical power had already increased throughout the world. No—it was still increasing, even now. Mutated Gates were appearing one after another, and Monster Waves had begun.

"Monsters are growing stronger as magical power increases. You know that too, Team Leader. But if people learn about this Mana Cultivation Method under the current circumstances…"

"Hunters' abilities will improve across the board. It's stable enough for even the lowest-ranked Hunters to learn without difficulty."

Team Leader Choi's expression hardened.

"I understand what you're thinking, Mr. Jin. Wasn't that why you suppressed the various rebel groups and terrorists in the first place—to reduce the possibility of the Mana Cultivation Method being misused as much as possible?"

"Yes. Before I worried about how sharp the weapon I'd made was, I had to think about whose hands it might end up in."

About two weeks ago in modern-world time, an incident in Texas had driven that point home: an attempted terrorist attack using a Magic Gem.

Fortunately, the terrorist's attempt had ended in failure, and there had been no casualties. But that incident had made me realize something for certain.

"When I said I wanted to share it with *everyone*, that included every kind of criminal and lunatic."

Afterward, I followed Magic Johnson to the Pentagon and obtained information about them with the tacit approval of the President of the United States. Alongside the people who had come with me, I dyed the desert red with blood and cut away every element that might become a threat.

Rebel groups that trained kidnapped children to shoot. Fanatical terrorists willing to carry out suicide attacks…

I killed anyone who stood in the way, and the dead were bound to the Skeleton King's undead army, which chased after those who fled.

For the ones farther away, we used captured leaders to send false orders: rebel groups were told to attack terrorist organizations, and terrorist organizations were told to attack rebel groups.

It was a war between bastards and motherfuckers. Tricked into launching all-out attacks on one another, both sides suffered massive losses.

"As you know, we couldn't wipe them out completely, and we won't be able to in the future. But we've achieved what we needed to for now. Even if those bastards learn this method, they won't be as dangerous as they were before."

They wouldn't be the only ones growing stronger from it. Hunters everywhere would improve enough to fight monsters strengthened by the rise in magical power. That should help keep the balance.

And if things get much worse…

Then I'd release the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique, too. So far, I'd taught it to only a handful of people, including Team Leader Choi.

The low-ranking Hunters who knew absolutely nothing about Mana Cultivation Methods would not be able to apply the Jin Family's Cultivation Technique even if I handed it to them right now. But once they had learned the method, they would be able to cultivate it on their own.

I met Team Leader Choi's eyes.

"We have to make it public. One way or another."

"…"

"Luckily, it isn't too late. The public still thinks pretty highly of both of us."

"Pretty highly" was an understatement. People were going wild over us.

I was being hailed as a young hero of a new age. After Butler Kim's death, Team Leader Choi had become Guild Master of the Peace Guild—and before the paint on his new nameplate had dried, he'd taken over the Ares Guild too.

Then there was the glow of his family name. His maternal grandfather was Cheon Taemin, the savior who had saved humanity from the Demon King Asmodeus. Team Leader Choi was his only blood relative and heir.

I grabbed his hand.

"Team Leader Choi."

I gripped it tight. When he met my fervent gaze, he flinched as though he'd been burned.

"W-Why are you doing this all of a sudden?"

He looked as though he'd run into Magic Johnson in a dark alley at night. I held on and pressed ahead.

"If you're that worried, let's try another way. Hm?"

"What way…?"

"Put your maternal grandfather's name to work for us just this once."

"What?"

"Come on. Let's cash in on the savior's name."

"…!"

Chapter 728

People are all the same.

Success after success makes them more confident, and before long, they start closing the eyes and ears they once kept wide open.

But Team Leader Choi was a decent person before he was an excellent Hunter or manager. Even though the decision was his to make, he always sought everyone's understanding.

"…So I'd like to hear what you all think."

When Team Leader Choi finished speaking in a low voice, the people sitting on the sofa fell silent for a moment.

No, *people* wasn't quite right. At some point, a monster had made himself at home among them.

And that monster looked more serious than ever.

"This body objects."

Every gaze turned toward him at the firm refusal, delivered without a hint of hesitation.

But the Skeleton King continued without a care.

"You all know why. Expand your influence too far, and people grow wary. Human envy and jealousy invite danger. Am I wrong?"

I'd thought this before, but the bastard really had become almost human.

When I awkwardly shook my head, the Skeleton King's voice gained even more force.

"This body would prefer to avoid any more attention, too. If other humans discover my true identity, it will cause trouble for all of you. So put an end to this foolish talk."

He ended his speech with a stern rebuke. The rest of us looked at one another as though we'd rehearsed it.

He had a point.

He definitely had a point, but…

"If you're so desperate to avoid attention, why'd you make an SNS account the second you got a phone?"

Team Leader Choi, Im Kkeokjeong, and Song Song nodded in turn.

"I agree with Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"Come to think of it, yeah. I don't use that stuff, so I hadn't realized, but he seems pretty famous."

"More than pretty famous. He hasn't even had the account long, and he's already got over a hundred thousand followers."

The Skeleton King, who had faltered after being struck in the heart of the matter, thrust out his chest at Song Song's words.

"As of today, a hundred and twenty thousand."

"Really?"

"Of course. Advertising offers are pouring in from all sides."

I watched him preen and let out a dry laugh.

"Look at this fucking bastard. Want me to split you into a hundred and twenty thousand bone fragments?"

"…"

"Delete the account. Now. That's your last warning."

After hesitating for a moment at my threat, the Skeleton King answered in a depressed voice.

"…Understood."

"At least you're obedient. But you didn't post any strange nonsense on SNS, did you?"

The internet's reach was staggering. In Murim, people sent messenger pigeons. Here, a few taps of a finger could send something around the world.

If that bastard posted some shit, we're in trouble.

Song Song broke in, sounding unconcerned.

"Fortunately, there's nothing much. I looked through everything just in case, and he's only posted a ton of pictures of his own face."

"Really?"

"Yeah. Most of his followers are overseas, too. And the overwhelming majority are men."

"That's a relief, but why would so many men… Ah."

It hit me.

I remembered whose hands had created the Skeleton King's handsome face.

Magic Johnson.

The Grand Mage of the century. And the century's gayest man.

Magic Johnson—the man said to work unbelievable magic with two staffs—had put plenty of his own taste into the Skeleton King's current appearance. The guy was handsome by any standard, but his face and build were perfectly suited to the tastes of a certain crowd.

A crowd of a hundred and twenty thousand.

That was enough people to kick the asses of a hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path if they came swarming back. Whether they'd stop at kicking was another question.

This guy's kind of impressive.

He'd gathered that many followers in no time without a name anyone knew or a face anyone recognized. Even the Murim Alliance Leader couldn't pull that off.

Oblivious to my newfound regard, the Skeleton King fiddled with his phone and spoke with a stricken look.

"I cannot bring myself to delete it. You are the most wicked, cruel human in the world."

"What crime did I commit in my previous life to deserve being called cruel by a monster bastard?"

"Ah, to part so suddenly. Somewhere, an unknown woman who can no longer gaze upon this body's dazzling face will weep without end."

"…"

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Nothing. You're better off not knowing."

Some truths were better left hidden.

I exchanged a glance with Song Song. With our silent agreement settled, I looked around.

"Anyway. Everyone's on board?"

Im Kkeokjeong nodded as if the answer were obvious.

"Well, if you and Team Leader Choi have decided, I'm with you."

"Song-i, what about you?"

"Hmm."

Song Song crossed her legs at an angle and continued.

"From what I've heard, we're doing this for everyone. If I say no, I'll be the only bitch here, won't I?"

"No."

"Really?"

"Yeah. You weren't all that nice to begin with."

"Oh, listen to this bastard."

Song Song smiled sweetly and raised her middle finger before suddenly sighing.

"What a ride. When Team Leader Choi offered me a transfer and I left the Ares Guild, I never imagined we'd end up here."

"You should've just stayed there."

"Hey, I couldn't. That Branch Leader was too much of a pervert. I figured I'd be better off working for someone young, handsome, and rich. But I got a bad feeling on the very first day."

"The first day?"

"Yeah. I'd come to get away from one pervert, and there was some other weird bastard waiting for me. I was starving, and he burned all the meat. Then, out of nowhere, he told me his star sign was Taurus. What kind of lunatic does that?"

"Ah-ha."

I gave a quiet laugh and looked at her without another word.

Truthfully, I felt bad for Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong. Ever since the Peace Guild was founded, they'd been dragged through one crisis after another. None of it was what they'd signed up for.

"Hmm."

"What's that look for?"

"Nothing. I just wanted to tell you that it isn't too late yet."

"What?"

"This could be a lot more dangerous than you or Uncle Kkeokjeong realize."

There was no laughter in my voice this time. Song Song's gaze turned serious.

"How dangerous are we talking?"

"We're past the point where this is just a domestic matter."

"You seem to have a tendency to underestimate yourself. You and Team Leader Choi left Korea behind a long time ago."

She wasn't exaggerating.

Ever since I took down the Arch Lich in China, my name had become known throughout the world. Meanwhile, Team Leader Choi had appeared in the media as the new City Lord of the Ares Guild and the successor to the living Savior.

But this was different. If anything, everything we'd achieved was what had created the problem.

I shrugged.

"Someone once said that the bigger you get, the more there is to take a bite out of."

"So how much are you planning to let them take?"

"I'm not. And I don't intend to start."

Song Song stared at me for a moment before suddenly speaking.

"You know something?"

"What?"

"It's way too late for us to back out. Both Uncle Kkeokjeong and me."

Im Kkeokjeong quietly added to her words.

"I wasn't planning to back out anyway."

"Uncle."

"Whether it's too late or not doesn't matter. Once you start something, you have to see it through to the end. At least for the sake of the one who left us first."

"…!"

"Right, Team Leader Choi?"

At Im Kkeokjeong's quiet question, everyone's gazes turned in one direction.

Team Leader Choi had gone quiet at some point. He was looking at the empty place someone had left behind. Until recently, it had still held that person's warmth. Now nothing could fill it.

He spoke.

"I visited the grave today. Someone had carved words beside the gravestone. 'Thank you for coming. I love you. Please come again.'"

No one said anything. Team Leader Choi continued calmly.

"So next time, I'd like all of us to go visit that person together. Next year, the year after that…and even decades from now."

It was the resolve of a man who had been forced to send someone precious on ahead.

The words *all of us together* carried his determination not to let the same thing happen again.

Decades from now.

Yeah. That was enough.

I didn't know what we'd look like then. For now, knowing we'd go forward together was enough.

"Team Leader Choi."

At my quiet call, he gave a heavy nod.

"Understood. Let's begin."

We'd already discussed the broad strokes. Team Leader Choi took out his phone and called the first person.

Beep. Beep. Click.

The call connected before it could ring a third time. A deep voice, practiced by a hectic life in politics, came from the other end.

"Speaking. Baek Hanseong here."

There were plenty of people named Baek Hanseong in Korea. But only one Team Leader Choi would call first in a situation like this.

"Yes, Mr. President. I'm calling about something important."

"Ha-ha. Well, putting it that way already makes me feel a little strange. I'm looking forward to it, but at the same time, I'm starting to feel uneasy."

At the appearance of a major figure who moved an entire country, Im Kkeokjeong and Song Song fell silent. The Skeleton King's eyes widened as he whispered to me.

"President Baek Hanseong? Is he—"

"That's right. Our country's pres—"

"I know. Isn't he the popular celebrity with more than ten million followers?"

"…"

"Damn it. A human has a hundred times this body's following."

As I watched the Skeleton King vent his frustration, I thought:

Please just fucking die already…

Come to think of it, he already had.

The corridor was dazzlingly bright. An A-rank Magic Gem filled with immense energy supplied power throughout the building, and every floor was crowded with people busy at work.

Until darkness fell without warning.

Crackle. Whoooosh.

The lights faded. Every machine stopped.

Confused shouts erupted from all around, shattering the momentary silence.

“What the hell?”

“Uh, looks like a power outage.”

“You call that an answer? Fuck… I told them to replace the Magic Gem before this happened. They’ve had a straw stuck in it for over twenty years, sucking it dry. It’s probably begging us to put it out of its misery.”

“Right? Though the experts said an A-rank Magic Gem would last at least thirty years.”

“So what, does it matter why the Magic Gem ran out ten years early? Are you so curious you’re about to go insane?”

“N-No, sir.”

“Enough. Everyone, focus! The Security Team and Technical Team will be here within two minutes, so don’t move a finger—stay exactly where you are! Anyone with spare mana lanterns, go get them right now.”

But despite the department head’s shout, the entire building lit up again before even a minute had passed. The power had returned.

“Damn it. Running around for nothing…”

The department head grumbled before waving away the Security Team, who had arrived a step too late.

“As you can see, everything’s fine. Any idea why the power went out?”

“I asked our team leader, too, and apparently it happens once every few years, although it’s rare. The Technical Team will have to investigate to find the exact cause.”

“Right. That’s their job.”

The Security Team Hunter gave an awkward smile and went through the checks. Had anything gone missing during the blackout? Was anyone hurt? Had anyone noticed anything suspicious?

But it was little more than a simple procedure, and there were mountains of work waiting to be handled. No one had the time or energy to devote to a blackout that had lasted barely a minute.

“Sorry, but could you come back if you have any more questions? We’re a little busy right now.”

The Security Team employee nodded at the department head’s words.

“Of course. You do look a lot busier than usual. Something going on?”

“A notice came down from above. Apparently, something big is going to happen sometime today.”

“Something big?”

“Yeah. We don’t know the details, but it looks like it came from the Blue House. Everyone’s on edge. At this rate, we can forget leaving on time.”

“Sorry. I’ve taken up your time.”

“Don’t worry about it. We’re all working for the country. Take care. See you later.”

“You too.”

But as they returned to their respective positions, none of them knew.

During that short span of less than a minute, some ghostlike entity had moved through every part of the building, riding the thick darkness.

And that one item had disappeared from the evidence storage room deep underground.

The hundreds of employees going about their work, the highly skilled Hunters of the Security Team, and even the alarm magic had failed to notice. The entity that had completed everything with ease leisurely slipped out of the building.

Step. Step.

Along with someone’s footsteps.

“Sehwan, did you check the third floor?”

“Yes, Team Leader. Nothing out of the ordinary. Any word from Technical?”

“It hasn’t even been ten minutes. You think they’ve found the cause already?”

“Fair point. By the way, isn’t the weather great today?”

Sssrk.

Behind the Security Team employee as he chatted with his superior, a dark shadow stirred faintly.

Chapter 729

I'd never gone fishing in my life, and I didn't know how.

But I did know how to catch more fish.

Bait.

That was what we needed. Scatter hints about a major announcement far and wide, then draw as much attention as possible from as many fish—or rather, people—as we could.

Of course, we'd need to do a little persuading along the way.

Team Leader Choi and I weren't trying to fill a bucket. We wanted a boat so full the catch spilled over the sides. And for that, we needed a good crew. The first person Team Leader Choi called was President Baek Hanseong.

"Pardon?"

He had gone through every kind of hardship before entering the Blue House at the age of just over forty. His eyes widened at the words *Mana Cultivation Method*, and when the name of one particular person followed, he spilled his coffee.

"I-Is that true? Did he really…?"

"Yes. My maternal grandfather created it himself. He wanted to share this Mana Cultivation Method with everyone."

"I-I can't believe it."

Who was Cheon Taemin?

A living savior. A hero who had accomplished something no one else in human history ever had.

He was the Slayer who had defeated the Demon King Asmodeus and brought the Great Cataclysm to an end. Everyone respected his name.

"But why is the Mana Cultivation Method called *Smiling*…?"

"…I took out the wrong one. Please forget what you just saw."

Honestly, if people knew I'd created it, I wouldn't care whether it was called *The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method* or *As-Salamu Alaykum*[3033].

But with Cheon Taemin's name attached, Team Leader Choi and I agreed that *The Smiling Mana Cultivation Method* was a problem.

"This is the Mana Cultivation Method my maternal grandfather created."

Team Leader Choi placed a neatly bound booklet on the table. A new name was printed on the cover.

"*Heaven and Earth Cultivation Technique*…"

"The Heaven and Earth Cultivation Technique is versatile enough for even the lowest-ranking Hunter to learn, and exceptionally safe. It won't produce

[3033] *As-salamu alaykum* is an Arabic greeting meaning "Peace be upon you."

tremendous results the moment someone learns it, but it will undoubtedly be a great help to Hunters.”

Of course it would. That was what I’d made it for.

The name had changed for grown-up reasons, but I’d come up with the new one too. Feeling a little proud, I added, “In short, it’s a fucking incredible Mana Cultivation Method.”

Team Leader Choi gave me a pointed cough, but President Baek Hanseong didn’t pay any attention. He didn’t seem to have any attention to spare.

He stared as though possessed at the booklet containing the principles of the Heaven and Earth Cultivation Technique. Only after a long while did he finally come to his senses.

“But why bring something this important to me…?”

“We need an ally.”

President Baek hadn’t bought the presidential chair secondhand on Oi Market. He understood at once why Team Leader Choi and I had come.

“You want a breakwater.”

“We hope we can support each other.”

“But no matter how large a Guild steps forward, it will be difficult as long as he is still here.”

A sound assessment.

If it were true.

Unfortunately, it isn’t.

We needed to avoid outside opposition as much as possible. That was why we were planning to reveal the Smiling—or rather, the Heaven and Earth Cultivation Technique while borrowing the name of the unconscious Cheon Taemin. Team Leader Choi had no intention of telling the truth even to President Baek Hanseong, who had always shown us a very favorable attitude.

He was a politician, after all.

“Neither I nor my maternal grandfather want any conflict or controversy. To prevent that, we need the government’s cooperation.”

“Does that mean the Blue House can announce the existence of this Mana Cultivation Method itself?”

Team Leader Choi shook his head.

“It should be enough to say we’ve been working together and that there’ll be a major announcement in two days. That alone will get the public’s attention.”

“So you want me to drum up interest…”

“This Mana Cultivation Method’s release will be announced as a sort of national project. If that happens, Korea’s standing will rise as well.”

“Hmm.”

The first public release of a Mana Cultivation Method in history. Korea's name would forever be tied to it—and so would the President's achievement.

A faint smile appeared around President Baek Hanseong's lips.

"The Korean flag looks especially fine today."

Someone once said the most powerful drug in the world was a patriotic high.

Flap—

Cheon Taemin. The public release of the Mana Cultivation Method. A national project.

Those three phrases brought everything to a boil like a cauldron over charcoal. The fire was lit in Korea.

> "My beloved and respected fellow citizens. I stand before you today to make an important announcement…"

President Baek made good on his promise to cooperate by calling an emergency press conference at the Blue House.

He spoke passionately before a crowd of reporters and cameras, including the foreign press. The conference went out live on television, spread across the world, and caused an uproar.

> **Mana Cultivation Method to Be Made Public—A Historic First!**
> **Savior of Humanity Saves the World Once Again!**
> **Will the Living Legend Finally Show Himself?**

Cheon Taemin's name alone was newsworthy after he'd stayed out of sight for so long. Now the Mana Cultivation Method he'd created was going to be released to the entire world.

The response was explosive.

No—the media had already exploded.

"Hey! Reporter Park! The Peace Guild! Call the Peace Guild!"

"I-I already did. I can't get a thing out of them."

"What about Ares? Don't you have a contact there? We've gotten tips from them before!"

"That person is in the detention center right now. You know, because he got caught up in the Go Jun incident a while back…"

"You're killing me. What about Choi Minwoo?"

“Oh, don’t even ask. Getting a line into them is practically impossible, and you couldn’t get a single drop of blood out of them even if you poked them.”

“Then Jin Taekyung?”

“…I’m the one who’d bleed if I tried him, Chief. Do you want to watch me get beaten to death?”

Sources of unknown origin were leaking out everywhere, but unless they made contact first, there was no way to learn more.

The media, at their wits’ end, could only churn out clickbait. Online, things were even worse.

> **Three-Line Summary of the Current Situation**
>
> 1. Cheon Taemin made a Mana Cultivation Method.
> 2. His grandson and a fucking awesome junior are pushing to make it public. The government’s jumping on the bandwagon.
> 3. Some Hunters probably didn’t even know what a Mana Cultivation Method was, but the one Cheon Taemin made is so versatile even the lowest-ranking Hunters can learn it.
>
> Wow! Let’s all level up!
>
> 4. That wasn’t three lines.
>
> └ **Author:** What the fuck are you talking about? I laid it out neatly.
> └ It’s not three lines in the KakaoPage[3034] viewer.
> └ **Author:** You crazy bastard.

> **The Mana Cultivation Method is going public?!**
> └ Written by Cheon Taemin?!
> └ Compiled by Jin Taekyung?!?!
> └ Wasn’t it compiled by Kim Gyeongsik?
> └ ? Who’s Kim Gyeongsik?
> └ Earthquake over here too, lol.
> └ An earthquake is totally justified this time. Everyone in our Guild lost their shit watching the official Blue House press conference.

[3034] KakaoPage is a Korean platform for digital fiction and comics.

> **I'm a civilian, so I don't really know, but what exactly is a Mana Cultivation Method?**
>
> └ To put it simply, it's a secret technique that only a tiny number of people can learn. Like the Zaha Divine Technique or the Fire Gate Divine Technique from wuxia[3035] novels. Those things are normally kept within their own circles, but this guy is saying screw that and making it available to everyone, yeah.
>
> └ I don't read wuxia[3036] novels, so I don't know.
>
> └ Okay, then think of it like a food recipe. Restaurants with Michelin stars all have their own recipes for the food they sell, right?
>
> └ What's Michelin?
>
> └ LOL… Then think of it as the sort of cooking secret every mother has.
>
> └ My mom is a terrible cook. I think she only knows the secret to making food taste bad.
>
> └ Hey. How old are you?
>
> └ Nine.
>
> └ Fuck, now I can't even properly swear at you.
>
> └ **Fact:** Curses very refreshingly at a nine-year-old.
>
> └ Fuck off.
>
> └ I'm an avid wuxia[3037] reader, but what's the Fire Gate Divine Technique? I know the Zaha Divine Technique.
>
> └ ? You don't read *Login Murim*?
>
> └ Zerobic, welcome.
>
> └ He took a break over the harvest festival last year. Not Zerobic—Bastardbic.

Netizens could usually find two sides to anything and argue about it without end. But beneath articles about the Mana Cultivation Method's release, they were united in praise.

Someone was giving away a secret technique of the kind others fought to keep hidden, with no restrictions at all.

Simply because they wanted to help everyone.

And the release wouldn't benefit only Hunters. Stronger Hunters could deal more quickly with the disturbing incidents that had been occurring one after another. Ordinary people would be safer too.

Of course, some people were disappointed for an entirely different reason.

[3035] *Wuxia* is a genre of Chinese fiction about martial artists and their adventures.
[3036] *Wuxia* is a genre of Chinese fiction about martial artists and their adventures.
[3037] *Wuxia* is a genre of Chinese fiction about martial artists and their adventures.

"Hmm."

"It would have been nice if you had given us some advance notice."

Ares Guild.

Choi Minwoo dipped his head at the cautious complaints from executives who had survived the upheaval within the Guild.

"I'm sorry I couldn't tell you beforehand. But I thought it best to act quickly, before the information leaked."

The executives exchanged glances at the young, capable new Vice Guild Master's apology.

He'd admitted fault first. That gave them grounds to press him—just enough to make sure he never acted on his own again.

But the problem was the terrifying legitimacy possessed by that Vice Guild Master who was young—no, barely more than a boy.

He stepped forward personally.

I've never even seen his face.

Does he care about his grandson that much?

Cheon Taemin hadn't appeared before them in a very long time.

Some executives recruited from outside had never even encountered their Guild Master after joining Ares Guild, while even executives with considerable seniority had begun harboring vague suspicions after Lee Jungryong's funeral.

Something's happened to the Guild Master.

It was a reasonable suspicion.

Cheon Taemin hadn't appeared at the funeral of Lee Jungryong, a man who had been practically his sworn brother. Nor had he intervened when Lee Jungryong sent his grandson from one overseas branch to another, all but exiling him.

But…things were different now.

Even if doubts still lingered, showing them would be incredibly foolish. Cheon Taemin's name still commanded their deepest respect. And his grandfather wasn't the young Vice Guild Master's only winning card.

"You're all awfully quiet."

A low voice broke the silence. Jin Taekyung, who had been watching a webtoon on his smartphone, continued:

"When someone apologizes to you, aren't you supposed to say something in response?"

"…!"

"Isn't that right?"

Dozens of pairs of eyes trembled, and throats bobbed nervously.

The executives exchanged glances, then bowed their heads with forced smiles.

That was when it happened.

Chapter 730

Knock. Knock.

Every eye turned toward the door.

Even the janitors at Ares Guild knew the entire leadership was in the conference room discussing important business. For someone to knock now, there were only two possibilities: the matter was just as important, or they'd already written their resignation letter.

Go Jun would have started swearing. Their new City Lord, though, didn't so much as twitch an eyebrow, even with the meeting finally going his way.

"Come in."

Click.

A middle-aged man appeared in the half-open doorway. The Chief Secretary approached Choi Minwoo and bowed.

"I'm sorry to interrupt the meeting, Vice Guild Master."

"That's all right," Choi said calmly. "If you have a good reason."

The Chief Secretary swallowed. He hadn't worked for Choi long, but he already knew his employer was quick to reward good work and punish mistakes. He also knew the report sent up from the lobby's Security Team a minute ago was beyond his authority to handle.

"An important guest has arrived."

He held out a trembling hand.

Choi's expression grew grave as he looked at what the secretary had brought him.

This is…

Recognition brought a rush of thoughts, but he didn't hesitate for long.

"Where is the guest?"

"Still in the lobby…"

"Show them to my private office. I'll be there shortly."

"Yes, sir."

The Chief Secretary answered as if he'd been waiting for exactly that instruction, then left. Choi turned back to the seated executives.

"I think we've covered the urgent matters. What do you all think?"

"Pardon?"

"Vice Guild Master, are you saying…?"

"If you'll excuse me, I think we should end today's meeting here."

Several executives stared at him in disbelief.

This was too much. However important the guest might be, how could he end a meeting attended by every overseas Branch Leader just like that?

Scrape.

“Vice Guild Master!”

One executive found the courage to leap to his feet.

Bang!

The sudden crash swallowed his voice.

Jin Taekyung lifted his hand from the alloy table, leaving a palm print in it.

“What, did they lay eggs? Why do these damn bugs keep flying around? Do we need to gut this conference room again?”

“…!”

“Oh, sorry. Go on with what you were saying. Vice Guild Master, where were you?”

The lone standing executive looked at Choi, his face stiff.

“Since things have turned out this way, I’d like to say something.”

His voice carried the determination not to back down this time. Several executives’ eyes gleamed, and Choi Minwoo calmly nodded.

“Yes, go ahead.”

“Then may I leave early?”

“…”

“It’s my wedding anniversary today…”

The others gave their colleague flat looks.

He’d been divorced for three years.

The Team Leader Choi I knew was a reasonable man.

Even when he had the power to crush someone, he knew when to ease off. He preferred to settle things as calmly and amicably as possible.

Which meant he wouldn’t dismiss dozens of executives with a few words over just anything.

That made me even more curious about the guest who had shown up so suddenly.

Ding.

“It was because of them, right? This important guest?”

I asked as soon as the private elevator doors closed.

“Half and half. I called the executives together to reassure them. There was never any room for trouble to begin with.”

“True. Most of the ones still around are on your side.”

“Even if someone had complaints, there was no reason for the Guild to oppose the publicization plan.”

“Because it also suggests that Cheon Tae… no, that your maternal grandfather is still going strong, Team Leader Choi. Right?”

“Yes. The reason Ares Guild hasn’t enjoyed its former standing is my maternal grandfather’s absence. In that sense, Mr. Jin’s proposal to use his fame was the best option for all of us.”

Cheon Taemin’s very existence was practically a cheat code in this world.

His name alone could command the attention of the entire world and send the hyenas lurking in the shadows, waiting for an opening, backing away.

Just like…

Yeah. Like the Martial God.

The thought came to me and hovered on the tip of my tongue, then faded. Team Leader Choi spoke again, his voice low.

“But unlike the Ares Guild executives, someone else can’t have been pleased by the news.”

“Someone else?”

He handed me something.

“The owner of this business card.”

Ding.

The elevator doors opened. We kept talking as we crossed a corridor that had been cleared on his orders.

“A business card? This?”

I frowned at the thing in my hand.

It was the size and shape of a business card, but could you really call it one? The platinum-colored surface gleamed, yet it bore no name, no title—not even a phone number.

The only thing I could guess was that its owner was an unimaginably wealthy magnate.

“This is heavier than I expected. Feels like it might actually be platinum. Are we meeting Middle Eastern royalty?”

“If that were the case, I would have finished the meeting and come.”

“Then who?”

“Look closely at the edge.”

I examined the card again. Only then did I notice the two birds engraved into it, one on each side.

This is…

“Do you know what kind of birds they are?”

“No idea.”

“Ravens.”

“Ravens?”

“Huginn and Muninn, to be precise.”

“What, the ravens have names? Aren’t they just ravens?”

"Someone without an interest in the subject might not know. They're creatures from mythology."

"Mythology?"

"Ancient Norse mythology."

Step. Step.

Our footsteps sounded unusually loud. As the office door drew nearer, Team Leader Choi continued.

"Huginn and Muninn are the two ravens associated with a god from those myths."

"Which god?"

"Odin."

"…!"

"You've heard that name plenty of times, haven't you?"

After a moment, I nodded.

Huginn and Muninn were new to me. Odin was another matter.

Oh, yeah. Another matter entirely.

Not just because he was a god everyone had heard of, or a character from the superhero movies I'd enjoyed as a kid.

Odin was a name known the world over.

Because Odin was the Guild everyone recognized as the best in the world.

Step.

We came to a stop. Beyond the door, I sensed a vast, carefully contained qi.

Team Leader Choi's calm voice crossed the quiet corridor.

"Let's go."

Click.

The door opened at last.

Someone standing before the fireplace slowly turned to face us.

At first, everyone thought it was a minor mishap.

They were busy and preoccupied with problems that needed immediate attention. And *it* had begun and ended in the blink of an eye.

But it was no minor mishap. The first to realize that was the youngest employee assigned to the evidence storage room.

"Um, Manager? I think we're missing a piece of evidence."

"What? What are you talking about?"

"I just checked the inventory, and we seem to be one item short…"

"Quit talking nonsense and check again, you idiot. Nothing's been taken out of storage in over a week."

The manager frowned, crossed his legs, and went back to watching his stocks.

Thirty minutes later, the youngest employee returned, scratching the back of his head.

“Manager, I really think it’s missing. One of the items connected to Go Jun is gone.”

“Hey, I told you. The storage room’s been locked for a week. My stock’s already hit its daily limit down,[3038] so stop pissing me off with this non—”

The manager broke off.

“What did you just say?”

“I told you. It really is gone,” the employee said, shrinking back.

“No, not that. What did you say right before that?”

“Huh? Oh—the items connected to Go Jun?”

“…!”

At the name that once again slipped from the youngest employee’s mouth, the manager felt a chill run down his spine.

Go Jun. Of all the things to go missing, it had to be evidence from the Go Jun case.

“Hey, the door. The door! Open the storage room right now! Get the others too—no, wait. Don’t call them yet!”

He jumped up and hurried to the evidence storage room. After he and the youngest employee spent hours searching every corner, he finally had to admit it.

Fuck…

It was gone. It really was gone.

The clueless junior hadn’t been talking nonsense. And the stock he’d bought the day before yesterday hitting its daily limit down was the least of his worries.

If word got out, his whole life would hit limit down.

What the hell is this?

Half dazed, he stared around the storage room. It made no sense.

They’d last checked the inventory only a week ago. Since then, no one had entered the room, yet an item had vanished without a trace.

Neither the anti-theft Magic placed on each piece of evidence nor the alarm Magic covering the entire room had gone off.

And it had to be evidence connected to Go Jun.

The mere disappearance of evidence was already enough to require him to write an incident report, but if evidence related to Go Jun had disappeared, this would not end with ordinary disciplinary action. The higher-ups had already collected the important pieces, but it had been an enormous case.

“…Seriously, this is driving me crazy.”

[3038] A daily limit down is the lowest price a stock is permitted to reach in a trading day under the exchange’s price-limit rules.

The manager felt the future go dark before his eyes. A civil servant's lifeline might be long, but it wasn't a steel cable. It could still be cut.

He pictured his tiger-like wife and rabbit-like children waiting at home. He couldn't bring himself to report it.

Right. Bury it. Just for now, and see what happens.

If he could talk the clueless junior around, he might find a way out later.

Decision made, he called to the youngest employee somewhere in the vast storage room, using the kindest voice he could muster.

"Are you there?"

"Ah, yes. I just got here."

"You went somewhere. Come over here for a moment. I have something important to discuss with you…"

He turned around and saw the youngest employee, eyes shining brightly.

Behind him stood the Security Team Leader, as imposing as an iron tower.

"What's going on?" the Security Team Leader asked. "I heard there was a problem."

"…?"

"Manager Kim?"

Fuck. I'm screwed.

The manager barely held back the curse. He opened his mouth, despair in his voice.

"It's gone."

"Pardon?"

"The necklace that came in among Go Jun's personal effects. It's gone."

Chapter 731

Step.

A glossy dress shoe pressed into the carpet.

The man had finally turned to face us, and one thought came to mind.

He looks like a crow.

Dressed in black from head to toe, he looked like a European gentleman who had wandered in from the nineteenth century. His suit didn't have a wrinkle in it, his coat collar stood high, and he wore a silk hat that had gone out of fashion a hundred years ago.

He was unmistakably Black, but his eyes, visible through a clear monocle, were a mysterious gold.

He studied us for a moment, then touched the brim of his hat in greeting.

"Pleased to meet you both."

His Korean came through smoothly, courtesy of translation Magic.

He was an uninvited guest who had appeared without an appointment, but we couldn't openly snub a messenger from Odin Guild. Besides, anyone carrying this much mana…

He's no ordinary messenger.

I gave the stranger a small nod, and Team Leader Choi offered him a seat.

"Please, sit down."

The three of us sat facing one another across a solid wood table. An odd silence settled over us before our guest broke it.

"I should introduce myself. I am Huginn of Odin Guild."

"The crow?"

I hadn't meant to say it aloud. Huginn gave a faint smile.

"Ah. I do have a real name, of course, but I have been called Huginn since I entered the Guild Master's service. You may call me that as well."

Once a Hunter made a name for himself, people often used an epithet based on his abilities more than his actual name. But no matter how hard I searched my memory, I couldn't place Huginn.

One of Odin's Guild Master's hidden right-hand men, maybe?

Even Korea's major Guilds kept plenty of secrets. I worked on the front lines; I could hardly expect to know the inner workings of a foreign Guild.

Especially Odin Guild.

There had been a time when Ares Guild was considered the best in the world. But a little over twenty years ago, Cheon Taemin vanished from the public eye without a trace.

People wondered what had happened. Lee Jungryong became Ares Guild's new captain, but no amount of skill could fill the void Cheon Taemin had left.

One year passed. Then five. Then ten.

Countless devoted followers of Cheon Taemin still called Ares Guild the best. Those who knew the reality—Hunters in particular—saw things differently.

To put it bluntly, Ares Guild had been a setting sun for the past ten years.

Odin Guild, meanwhile, was the rising sun.

Based in Europe, they had rapidly expanded their influence while Ares Guild was faltering. Along the way, they acquired and merged with several major Guilds, rising into a giant that no one could deny.

A giant powerful enough to send a mere messenger to Ares Guild's new master.

"I've come today to convey the Guild Master's congratulations."

At Huginn's words, Team Leader Choi calmly opened his mouth.

"Is that so?"

"Yes. He is delighted to see a capable young man with all the right qualifications take charge of Ares Guild."

It sounded like praise. It wasn't.

I ran my tongue over my lips.

Well, look at these bastards…

Some things showed through no matter how much wrapping you piled on. Huginn's courteous tone and manner couldn't hide what lay beneath them.

Looking down on us from the start.

I felt as if we were receiving an envoy from an overlord state. Team Leader Choi wasn't too stupid to notice, or rash enough to show his displeasure openly.

"That is rather high praise while my maternal grandfather is still with us, but I'm grateful nonetheless. Grateful enough to want to thank him in person."

Huginn kept smiling despite the barb.

"Ah, he was very sorry he could not come himself."

"The Guild Master must be busy. I'd heard he had withdrawn from public life several years ago… but it seems you can't trust rumors."

The higher someone rose, the harder it became to get them out of their seat. That was an eternal truth. Cheon Taemin, who had reportedly vanished altogether, was simply an extreme case.

Most major Guild Masters limited their contact with the outside world. Odin's Guild Master was no different.

"Even so, he is someone I have always respected, so I would like to visit him and pay my respects. What do you think?"

"Haha. Well…"

Huginn laughed aloud and laced his fingers together.

"I'm sorry, but he has been so busy lately that I doubt it would be possible."

"It sounds as though something has happened."

"Yes. A minor matter, though quite troublesome in its way. He seems to be giving a great deal of thought to how he should handle it. The others are, too."

"The others?"

"Acquaintances he has known for many years. The person he is meeting today is from Kronos… Ah, my apologies. I shouldn't have said that."

The name of another major Guild—one of the world's Ten Great Guilds alongside Ares—had slipped out.

Team Leader Choi spoke quietly. "Kronos Guild."

"I would appreciate it if you could forget you heard that. I make mistakes like this from time to time, and the Guild Master calls me in for a reprimand."

The troubled look on Huginn's face made me let out a short laugh.

"What mistake?"

"Pardon?"

"Mr. Crow, drop the half-assed acting. Let's talk honestly."

Hmm. Maybe I should have just kept watching.

But listening to him felt like choking down a hundred sweet potatoes without a drop of dongchimi broth to wash them down.[3039] I couldn't take it anymore.

I leaned back into the plush sofa.

"To put it bluntly, you came because of the Mana Cultivation Method that's about to be released, right? Stop at a reasonable point. If you go any further, this won't be fun. We can join hands with another major Guild like Kronos and bury you, so don't get cocky. That's what you wanted to say, isn't it?"

"…"

"Fuck's sake. We all know what this is about, so why give ourselves headaches talking in circles? We're not recording you. Say what you came to say and go. Right?"

Huginn listened to the whole torrent without a word, then turned to Team Leader Choi.

"I hesitated to mention this for fear of being discourteous, but must Mr. Jin be present?"

"Of course."

Team Leader Choi's reply was calm.

"Mr. Jin is that important. And if you wanted to speak with me alone, you should have said so at the outset."

"Then may I ask to speak with you alone now?"

[3039] Dongchimi is a watery radish kimchi commonly served chilled with its broth.

"I refuse."

There wasn't a moment's hesitation in Team Leader Choi's answer. Huginn blinked his golden eyes.

"Well… this is awkward."

"We feel the same. Had you made an appointment, we could have arranged any number of things beforehand."

"Hm."

Huginn adjusted his monocle.

"Since I was the first to be rude, I owe you both a formal apology."

Would you look at him.

I'd thought the crow getup was just a gimmick, but apparently he hadn't dressed like a gentleman for nothing. Since Huginn was being so courteous, I answered like a gentleman myself.

"You were rude first, so I'm not apologizing."

"…"

"I already understand how you feel, so don't stare at me like that. As I said earlier, let's just have an honest conversation. Okay?"

Huginn sighed and nodded.

"Very well. Since you insist, I shall be direct."

"Keep it short. Get to the point."

Huginn's monocle flashed beneath the office's lighting Magic. The brief silence ended as he looked from me to Team Leader Choi and spoke.

"Stop the release of the Mana Cultivation Method. If you refuse, there will be consequences."

It was a single sentence that fulfilled my request to get straight to the point one hundred percent—and made us feel even worse than I had expected.

"Well, I figured that was coming, but… fuck, it's unpleasant to hear. Don't you think?"

Team Leader Choi shrugged.

"Isn't it better than listening to him talk in circles again?"

"That's true. If he'd done that one more time, I really would've…"

"You must control yourself."

"I was going to, even without you telling me. I don't want to make this a bigger problem. Though I probably would've told him to take off the monocle first."

Team Leader Choi let out a short laugh. Huginn's eyes narrowed.

"You are every bit as rude as I was told."

"You're being pretty damn unpleasant too. I'd never heard of you, much less seen you."

"Do you intend to make a show of force here?"

“If I have to. Once you take off that monocle.”

“Listen, Mr. Jin.”

“Yes, hello? Go ahead.”

“Do not lose your temper. This is merely a proposal.”

“Your mouth may be crooked, but you should still speak straight. To my ears, that sounds like a threat, not a proposal.”

“If you choose to hear it as a threat, it may well become one. But your opinion is not what matters to me.”

Huginn answered firmly, then turned toward Team Leader Choi.

“What will you do, Mr. Choi?”

His golden eyes gleamed coldly. A voice filled with force slipped between Huginn’s lips.

“Make the choice yourself.”

Huginn was certain.

He can’t refuse this.

It was an ultimatum in all but name. Anyone with the slightest sense would back down.

Jin Taekyung was unpredictable to the point of being half-mad. But the young Asian man before Huginn, Choi Minwoo, would make a different choice.

Besides…

The Slayer won’t intervene. Master said so. That makes it a fact.

The assurance had come from the one man to whom Huginn gave his absolute loyalty. His Master had never been wrong. Choi Minwoo’s answer was as good as decided.

Perhaps that was why his response, when it came, sounded only natural.

“Since things have come to this, I suppose I have no choice. All right.”

“As expected. You are a wise man, Mr. Choi.”

Huginn felt his composure returning after his exchange with Jin Taekyung. He recovered his smile.

“Then I may take it that tomorrow evening’s release of the Mana Cultivation Method has been canceled entirely?”

“Of course. I’ve changed my mind.”

“Excellent. He will be pleased to hear it.”

Huginn rose and added, “As will the others.”

“I hope so,” Choi Minwoo said.

“They are reasonable people. From now on, we should be able to establish a good relationship in a more amicable atmosphere.”

With that pointed remark, Huginn looked at Jin Taekyung.

Only moments ago, Jin had been spouting vulgarities to his face. Now he was practically lying back on the sofa, fiddling with his smartphone.

Rude to the very end.

But satisfaction outweighed Huginn’s annoyance. He had won.

Before leaving, he adjusted his silk hat like the cultured gentleman he was and offered Jin his hand.

“Mr. Jin, I was discourteous today, though I did not intend to be. I hope we can meet with smiles next time.”

Only a winner had the privilege of mocking the loser with kind words. When Jin refused his hand and gave a curt reply instead, Huginn felt better still.

“You’re in a hurry. It hasn’t even finished uploading.”

“I have an urgent matter to attend to. Good day.”

His business here was done. Huginn gave Choi Minwoo a polite nod, turned, and headed for the door.

Step. Step.

His light footsteps crossed the carpet. But Huginn was forced to stop in front of the door.

He couldn’t ignore what Jin had just said.

“Did you say…?”

Huginn turned back, his words trailing off. He stared at Jin as if he couldn’t believe it.

Jin blinked.

“Hm? Oh, uploading?”

“Uploading…?”

“Yeah. It’s nothing important. You should get going—you look busy.”

Uploading. Uploading. Uploading.

The word throbbed in Huginn’s ears in time with his heartbeat.

“What. Exactly. Did you. Upload?”

And the answer to his clipped question came not from Jin Taekyung, but from Choi Minwoo.

“Didn’t I tell you? I changed my mind.”

“Surely not.”

“The Mana Cultivation Method. We’ve decided to release it today.”

“…!”

Chapter 732

Civilization sure is convenient.

You can store enormous amounts of data on a smartphone smaller than your palm, then share whatever you want with everyone else by moving a finger a few times.

Granted, all that technology had restricted what I could do until now. This time, though, it worked in my favor.

Mr. Jin Taekyung. Do you have the file with you?

Remembering the Sound Transmission Team Leader Choi had sent me just a few minutes ago, I let out a quiet laugh.

I waved my smartphone at Huginn, who stood frozen like a statue.

“See this?”

The screen’s light flickered in Huginn’s golden eyes.

At Team Leader Choi’s request, I had uploaded the file to a personal social media account I’d created months ago and never used. The words **Post published** were displayed on the screen.

“Guess that’s what you get in the Vice Guild Master’s office. Even the Wi-Fi’s on another level. The file’s pretty big, too, though it might not look like much.”

“…Mr. Jin.”

His voice sounded ready to boil over. I blinked my deer-like eyes at him.

“Hm? What?”

“What, exactly, have you done?”

“A good deed.”

Huginn’s skin flushed dark red. He took a deep breath before speaking again, his voice controlled.

“Delete it now. It is not too late.”

I put on a serious face.

“Should I? Honestly, I’m a little scared too.”

“A poor decision can still be corrected.”

“Easier said than done. You know how scary the world is these days. It’s probably spreading everywhere already.”

Buzz. Buzz. Bzzzz.

Before I’d finished speaking, my phone began vibrating nonstop.

Huginn realized the vibrations were notifications that people were sharing the post, and anxiety settled over his face.

“It has only been a few dozen seconds. We can still contain this.”

“Oh? Really?”

"You have my word."

"But people are going to curse me out. They'll say I baited everyone and then deleted the post and ran. I already scattered so much bait everywhere that this won't end with just a moderate amount of abuse."

"For now, you could announce that the Mana Cultivation Method needs further improvement… No. Rather than waste time discussing it, why not delete the post immediately?"

At Huginn's urging, I let out a soft sigh.

"I'd like to, but there's one thing I can't stop thinking about."

"Tell me. I will take care of it."

"What should I have for dinner tonight?"

"…?"

"Dinner. What could I eat that would make people say I'd had a great meal? What do you think, Team Leader Choi?"

Beside the motionless Huginn, Team Leader Choi answered thoughtfully.

"Kimchi stew."[3040]

"Kimchi stew?"

"Yes. Kimchi stew boiled with plenty of pork. And white rice."

"Oh, you know your food."

The moment I exclaimed in admiration—

Crack.

Bones shifted inside someone's tightly clenched fist. Huginn trembled for several seconds, then spoke in a low voice.

"So you insist… on making a foolish choice."

I shrugged.

"Why? Not a fan of Korean food?"

"I promise you, you will regret this."

"If you feel that strongly, I guess I have no choice. We'll have soybean paste stew instead of kimchi stew tonight. What do you think, Team Leader Choi?"

Team Leader Choi nodded.

"Either is fine with me. I'm hungry, as it happens."

"That's because we've been listening to bullshit since early evening. A dog barking once or twice can be cute, but it gets tiring when it won't stop."

I looked at Huginn and added, "Especially when it isn't my dog, but a mutt raised in the neighborhood next door."

"…!"

[3040] Kimchi is a Korean dish of fermented vegetables, commonly napa cabbage.

“Don’t know who owns it, but what’s the world coming to? Who lets a dog run loose without a leash or a muzzle these days?”

Muttering as if to myself, I glanced at my phone.

Five in the afternoon.

Dinner wouldn’t be too early, but oddly enough, I wasn’t hungry today.

The reason was probably…

Buzz. Buzz. Bzzzz.

The share notifications still coming in without a break.

“Team Leader Choi, how many followers did my account have? I made it and hardly ever checked.”

“More than five hundred million, as far as I know.”

“Five hundred million? That many?”

“It’s a popular social media platform worldwide, across countries and races. Of course, nearly half your followers are Chinese.”

“Wow. I should thank the Arch Lich.”

Huginn had been listening to us. Now he spoke coldly.

“I once heard a Korean proverb. ‘After losing the cow, repair the pasture.‘”

“Guess you didn’t hear it from a Korean. It’s a barn, not a pasture.”

“Pasture, stable—what does it matter? What matters is that the two of you have made the worst possible choice today.”

“We’ll see about that.”

“I assure you, before long you will lose everything. And then you will have nothing left to repair.”

At Huginn’s vicious words, I snorted quietly.

“The longer I look at you, the harder it is to tell whether you’re a crow or a bastard dog.”

“…Mr. Jin.”

“You’re a servant sent to deliver a message. You talk too much. If you’ve got more to say, bring your master here. Tell him to stop acting so important, like he really is a god.”

The moment I finished speaking, wind gusted from somewhere.

The vast mana pouring from Huginn’s body writhed. His aura was easily powerful enough for an S-rank Hunter—everything I’d expected, and more.

But the power that seemed ready to overflow in every direction stopped dead at Team Leader Choi’s quiet words.

“I cannot take responsibility for what happens next.”

“…”

“If you are prepared for that, do as you wish, Mr. Huginn.”

A brief silence passed.

The surging mana slowly subsided. The icy chill faded from Huginn's golden eyes, and the hand that had twitched toward something inside his clothes returned to its place.

Pat. Pat.

He straightened his clothes, which had briefly fallen out of order, and spoke with a stiff expression.

"I have been discourteous. I apologize."

I clicked my tongue at how readily he admitted it.

Too bad I wouldn't get to smash that neat monocle. But it couldn't be helped. The trouble we'd stirred up here today was enough for now.

No need to provoke him any further.

Odin Guild was undeniably a giant, and it cast a shadow to match.

Huginn himself was unknown to the outside world. There was no telling how many other S-rank Hunters Odin Guild had hidden away.

And the other major Guilds will probably side with Odin.

Half-crushing Huginn's face now would cost us more than we'd gain. Team Leader Choi knew it, and so did Huginn, despite his momentary loss of composure.

"I should be going. I expect we will meet again soon."

Still playing the gentleman, Huginn headed for the door with that pointed farewell. Team Leader Choi made sure to give him one last reply.

Or rather, one last bluff.

"I will remember Odin Guild's intentions. So will Mr. Jin Taekyung. And so will my maternal grandfather."

"…I understand."

Something appeared in Huginn's eyes as he answered—surprise, perhaps, or doubt. Then he was gone.

Click.

Team Leader Choi stared silently at the firmly closed door and muttered:

"So it begins."

"Well, we knew they'd try to stop us. With the release announced for tomorrow, they had no reason to hold back."

"They were more blatant than I expected. And…"

His voice trailed off. Team Leader Choi glanced briefly at the empty space Huginn had left behind before continuing.

"I doubt they sent a messenger only because of the Mana Cultivation Method."

"You mean?"

“I had the feeling he came to confirm someone’s absence. Someone as important to them as the Mana Cultivation Method the world will see tomorrow. Perhaps more important.”

I closed my mouth and quietly repeated one person’s name.

Cheon Taemin.

The living savior. A Hunter unlike any who had come before, or would ever come again.

The whole world revered him, and his strength was said to be beyond anyone’s reach. If the enemies hiding in the shadows learned he could not step forward, they would not hesitate to attack.

“But his condition is our most closely guarded secret.”

Only six people knew that Cheon Taemin was in a vegetative state.

Team Leader Choi and me. Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong. The Skeleton King and Magic Johnson.

Everyone who had known the truth before them was already dead.

Lee Jungryong. Song Cheonwoo. And finally, Go Jun.

In the past and even now, the truth about Cheon Taemin was something that could never be revealed to the outside world. And Magic Johnson, whom we had been forced to ask for help, was someone Team Leader Choi had more than enough reason to trust.

He was the one who had moved Cheon Taemin out of the secret area and cast several protective spells over him.

Wait. Magic?

My expression stiffened as a thought struck me. Team Leader Choi nodded.

“Do you remember what Mr. Johnson said in Ares Guild’s Area A?”

“…A mage.”

“Yes. Lee Jungryong had help. Mr. Johnson said Area A had been constructed by a mage on the level of a Grand Mage.”

“Then, could it be…”

“The secret could have been leaked from the very beginning.”

“…!”

“And if they already know…”

Team Leader Choi took a breath.

“This could be a difficult fight. Far more difficult than we expected.”

So why did he look so calm? Despite the gravity of his words, both his voice and his expression were composed.

“Why are you looking at me like that?” he asked.

I scratched my chin. “Maybe it’s just me, but you seem pretty relaxed for someone saying all that.”

"Pardon?"

"No, it feels like your words and actions don't match. You've always been the kind of person who put safety first, but just now, you didn't even blink before using your grandfather's name to make a bluff."

Team Leader Choi blinked, then gave a quiet laugh.

"Isn't it obvious?"

"What is?"

"You're here, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"…Huh?"

"No matter how powerful a card our enemies play, I have a Joker card named Jin Taekyung. Naturally, that makes me bolder."

For a moment, I couldn't think of a reply. I stood there stammering like Mute Samryong,[3041] and Team Leader Choi's smile deepened.

"Oh, and…"

"And? What else?"

"I'm hungry. Let's have kimchi stew tonight, as we first decided."

Pat, pat.

Team Leader Choi tapped me on the shoulder, picked up his coat, and left the office. I stood there dazed for a moment, watching his back with an incredulous expression.

Team Leader Choi had changed. He hadn't used to be like this.

But, well…

I don't mind it.

I muttered inwardly and followed him.

Even now, the smartphone in my pocket continued to buzz without end.

[3041] *Mute Samryong* is a Korean short story by Na Do-hyang.

Chapter 733

At some point, I'd become the kind of person who could go three days and nights without sleep and still be fine. Even so, getting a good night's rest was a wonderful thing.

Especially when I woke up refreshed in a place where I was staying with my precious family.

"Home really is the best."

I sat down at the enormous dining table, and Team Leader Choi gave me a sour look from across it.

"This is my home, technically."

"Is that important right now?"

"I would say so. It is a matter of legal ownership."

"I'm starting to wonder if homeless people can even bear to live."

"Anyone listening would think you really had no house and no money."

As if.

I had a house in my own name now, and more money than I knew what to do with.

But even with trillions of won[3042] sitting in my bank account, I'd be hard-pressed to find a safer place for my family and me to stay.

No. At least not anywhere in Korea.

From the outside, it looked like an enormous mansion. In reality, it was an impregnable fortress wrapped in layer upon layer of protective Magic.

And since the public still knew it as Cheon Taemin's mansion, it would not be an exaggeration to say that it carried more symbolic weight than even the Blue House.

With everyone watching, breaking in is practically impossible. Even if an S-rank Hunter attacked, we could buy more than enough time.

For someone like me, who put my family's safety above all else in every situation, it was the perfect place.

Of course, Team Leader Choi might feel differently about suddenly having us as housemates.

"Now that I think about it, I'm being pretty shameless. Should I start paying rent this month?"

"If you offer, I will accept it. At ten million won[3043] per person, forty million[3044] a month should do."

[3042] Trillions of won—roughly two to nine trillion—are about $1.4–6.4 billion or €1.3–5.8 billion.

[3043] Ten million won is about $7,100 or €6,500.

[3044] Forty million won is about $29,000 or €26,000.

I gazed out the window at the sunlight pouring down and muttered:

“Ah, nice weather.”

“…”

“Anyway, why’s the rent so high? You even got the math wrong.”

“My calculations are always accurate.”

“What are you talking about? Ten million each makes thirty million[3045], not forty. My father died ages ago.”

“There is one more person.”

No sooner had Team Leader Choi said it than a blond foreigner came ambling down the hall and dropped into a chair.

“Feed me.”

Speak of the fucking devil.

Putting everything else aside, the very first thing he said after getting up and seeing our faces made it clear he was a first-rate lout.

“You gonna get your own damn food, or eat after I smack you?”

The Skeleton King considered his options carefully.

“I shall get my own food.”

“Good choice. Bring mine while you’re at it.”

“…?”

“Oh, and don’t forget the soup. Forget it and you’re dead.”

One of the mansion’s best features was the artificial intelligence in the kitchen, which always had hot food ready.

A little later, the Skeleton King brought me a meal, grumbling all the while. Team Leader Choi watched as I polished off my yukgaejang.[3046]

“Mr. Jin Taekyung, you always eat well.”

“People aren’t machines. You have to eat to live.”

“Did you sleep well?”

“Yes. It’s been a while. I probably collapsed almost the moment I lay down.”

Team Leader Choi nodded as if he had expected that answer.

“So that is why you could not answer your phone.”

“My phone?”

“You received calls from several places during the night. Have you still not checked?”

“Huh?”

[3045] Thirty million won is about $21,000 or €19,000.

[3046] Yukgaejang is a spicy Korean soup made with shredded beef, vegetables, and red pepper seasoning.

Only then did I check my smartphone. It had vibrated so much that I had switched it to silent, but there were now more than a hundred missed calls and messages that had piled up since last night.

What the hell?

The names scattered through the list were too familiar—and too illustrious—to write off as ads or spam.

Prince Felix of the United Kingdom, whom I had met during the operation to suppress the Arch Lich. Faye Chen, an S-rank Hunter.

Chuck Hagel of the United States, with whom I had destroyed a terrorist organization only two weeks ago by modern reckoning, and Magic Johnson, a name that had become impossible to leave out.

That wasn't all.

President Baek Hanseong was on the list, of course. So were President Doramp Jr. of the United States, whom I had met during my visit to the Pentagon, and Chairman Xiao Yang of China.

"It was a long night," Team Leader Choi said, raising his coffee cup with a tired look. "Longer than I expected. Though I did hear quite a bit of news."

"News?"

"Yes. Chairman Xiao Yang, in particular, passed along something interesting."

Tap, tap.

Team Leader Choi tapped the tablet PC in front of him with one long finger. A hologram rose above the screen and projected dozens of images.

Flash.

"…What is this?"

Once the images had formed, I frowned and put down my spoon.

I had a strong stomach and was used to gruesome sights, but I couldn't keep eating while I looked at these.

"Why are there so many corpses?"

"They were prisoners who were alive and well and incarcerated at Beijing Special Detention Center as recently as last night. And among them are some faces you know, Mr. Jin Taekyung."

"I do?"

Swish.

Team Leader Choi waved a hand instead of answering. The images scattered and vanished, all but one, which expanded before me.

"Do you recognize him now?"

I studied it in silence.

The middle-aged man lay there peacefully, as though deep in sleep. His face was familiar, but the Skeleton King recalled his name before I did.

"That human. His name was, ah… Wu Xueming? Some peculiar name like that."

He smiled smugly when Team Leader Choi and I looked at him.

"Ha-ha. You underestimate the information-gathering abilities of this body. Unlike lazy creatures such as yourselves, I devoted myself to my smartphone even at the expense of my sleeping hours."

"You just couldn't sleep. You're dead, after all."

"…"

The Skeleton King grew dejected and began picking at his yukgaejang. Team Leader Choi nodded before speaking.

"Former Premier of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, and a member of the Politburo Standing Committee. And…"

I finally remembered everything about Wu Xueming and cut in.

"Wu Heixing's father. His son was the bastard who teamed up with Lee Jungryong to kill me."

"Correct. Wu Xueming was effectively China's second most powerful man, and the leader of the Crown Prince Party—Chairman Xiao Yang's strongest political rival."

I knew all that. After the operation against the Arch Lich, Wu Xueming had raised questions about his son's death, and I'd learned plenty about him.

One of the main reasons Wu Heixing had been able to cause so much trouble and get away with it was his father's family. The Wu clan was among China's most distinguished.

But…

"Didn't all that corruption come out and knock Wu Xueming out of power? Last I heard, he was waiting for trial."

"That is correct. Chairman Xiao Yang seized the opportunity, and most of the Crown Prince Party, including Wu Xueming, was imprisoned."

"And now Wu Xueming is suddenly dead?"

"Wu Xueming was still middle-aged, and he had spent decades drinking potions like water for the sake of his health. His cause of death was sudden cardiac arrest, but there is no way he and some fifty of his relatives could all die the same way at the exact same time."

"Relatives? Then those pictures…"

"According to Chairman Xiao Yang, every one of them belonged to the Wu family. Some were children."

"…!"

The annihilation of an entire household.

Those words sounded like something out of Murim. A chill ran down my spine, and an almost unbelievable thought struck me.

"Team Leader Choi. You don't think…"

But before I could finish, Team Leader Choi shook his head.

"Chairman Xiao Yang did not do this. If anything, he wanted to win Wu Xueming over more than anyone."

Win him over.

Wu Xueming had been Xiao Yang's greatest political rival. Now that he had no hope of a comeback, Xiao Yang had no particular need to kill him. Then again, he had no reason to keep him alive, either.

So what did he hope to gain by winning him over? What did Wu Xueming have?

The Crown Prince Party's collapsed influence? His vast fortune, which was all but certain to be seized?

I silently rolled the word *persuade* around in my mind. Before long, I realized the answer.

"…The Mana Cultivation Method."

At the single word that escaped like a groan, the Skeleton King blinked, and Team Leader Choi answered in a low voice.

"Yes. Chairman Xiao Yang was trying to win Wu Xueming over in order to obtain the very Mana Cultivation Method that had turned Wu Heixing into an S-rank Hunter."

An S-rank Hunter with that level of power would naturally discover a unique training method of his own at some point.

But Wu Heixing had been different. He had already learned a Mana Cultivation Method passed down through his family, and after his death and Wu Xueming's downfall, I had stopped paying much attention to the matter.

But the fact that Wu Xueming and all his relatives suddenly died last night means…

I didn't care what Xiao Yang planned to do with the method. What mattered was that the destruction of the Wu family had ended his attempt to get it—and who had done that.

I already knew the answer.

"Odin Guild."

A dry voice, unfamiliar even to me, slipped between my lips. Team Leader Choi ran his fingers over his coffee cup, which had gone cold.

"That seems most likely."

"…"

"According to Chairman Xiao Yang, Wu Xueming appeared willing to cooperate. He had little choice. If he refused to hand over the Mana Cultivation Method, he faced life imprisonment at the least, and possibly execution. But…"

Team Leader Choi trailed off and bit his lip.

"Someone else would not have wanted that."

It felt as though the blood throughout my body had frozen.

They had made their move. Faster than I'd expected, and with far more cruelty.

But even so, to wipe out an entire household…

I looked at the hologram, still hovering above the table. Women, children, old people. All of them lay in a sleep from which they would never wake.

Simply because they had been born into the Wu family.

Did they go this far to stop the Mana Cultivation Method from getting out? Or…

Was this a reply to what happened last night?

The thoughts hovered on the tip of my tongue, then scattered. I stared at the faces of the dead for a while before speaking.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes. Please, go ahead."

"If you've got time, want to go out for coffee?"

"I do not mind. But where would we go all of a sudden?"

"Let's see. Was it Paris?"

"What?"

Team Leader Choi looked at me, puzzled. I went on calmly.

"Odin Guild. I feel like going to see the boss's ugly mug."

"…!"

Chapter 734

Team Leader Choi rarely showed a change in expression.

He kept his feelings to himself, and in interviews he stuck to the essentials. Even veteran reporters—the kind who claimed they'd grabbed a microphone at their first-birthday celebration—struggled to get a word out of him.[3047]

But Team Leader Choi was flesh and blood. Sometimes he showed plenty of emotion, especially when he was talking to me. Then he let out everything he usually kept hidden.

Like now.

"Odin Guild. I feel like going to see the boss's ugly mug."

"…!"

The instant I finished speaking, his mouth fell open in a daze. Beneath his trembling eyelids, his pupils were already shaking like an earthquake.

This bastard's planning to cause trouble again.

Team Leader Choi stared at me with exactly that look in his eyes. After a long silence, he finally managed to force out his voice.

"Are you serious?"

"Hm."

I thought for a moment.

"Maybe fifty-fifty?"

"So you're half-insane."

"Is that how it works?"

"I am genuinely curious. Where did this insane idea of going to see the Odin Guild Master right now come from? Your heart or your head?"

"My heart."

Team Leader Choi sighed.

"That is a relief, at least. You have not gone completely insane."

"You're calling a perfectly sane person crazy? I'm just planning to look the man in the face and have a cup of coffee with him. Ares Guild has branches in France anyway, so I can use that as an excuse and kill two birds with one stone…"

"It is a Guild branch, not a chain store. And you expect me to believe that? Are you joking?"

At Team Leader Choi's utterly serious question, I smacked my lips.

"Well, if the conversation doesn't go smoothly, there might be a little trouble."

"I will take that to mean an enormous amount of trouble."

[3047] Doljabi is a Korean first-birthday ceremony in which a child chooses an object thought to hint at their future.

I almost asked what he was making such a big deal about, but stopped myself.

I couldn't honestly say his concern was exaggerated. It had only been a few weeks in the modern world since I'd stormed into Ares Guild alone and cracked Go Jun's skull.

Can't exactly argue after pulling a stunt like that.

Besides, I wasn't an idiot. I knew perfectly well that following my heart right now would probably end badly.

"All right."

"The Eiffel Tower collapses, the Guild collapses, public opinion turns into a wasteland… What?"

"I said all right."

Team Leader Choi, already a step ahead of me in his hallucinations, blinked.

"Really?"

I gave a small nod.

"We don't have a pretext."

Even in Murim, where human lives were worth no more than livestock, you needed at least some justification. If I flew to Paris and picked a fight with Odin Guild now, all I'd get was an Interpol wanted notice.

At least I had public support when I dealt with Go Jun.

That incident had caused an international stir, but it had happened in Korea. Unlike this time, there had been clear testimony and evidence. The public had also been furious over Go Jun's many crimes against humanity.

Those were the reasons I'd been able to step outside the law without becoming a criminal.

Paris would be different.

My heart was screaming at me to storm into Paris and raise hell, but the part of my reason that was still alive was facing reality.

Team Leader Choi's eyes widened at my decision. The Skeleton King, who had been staring at his smartphone while shoveling down yukgaejang,[3048] dropped his spoon.

"This cannot be. Did you just say 'pretext'?"

"Impossible. You bastard, you're a monster! What have you done with the treacherous human?"

"…"

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, this is a simple verification procedure. Please do not take offense. Where did we first meet?"

"Doppelganger! Get out of the treacherous human's body!"

These two were acting like fucking idiots.

[3048] Yukgaejang is a spicy Korean beef soup, usually made with shredded beef and vegetables.

Instead of answering, I picked up the spoon on the table and smacked the Skeleton King on top of his head.

Crack!

“My skull! My beautiful skull!”

Team Leader Choi watched the Skeleton King howl and nodded.

“What a relief. You are Jin Taekyung.”

“…”

After completing that strangely unpleasant verification procedure, Team Leader Choi let out a sigh of relief.

“In any case, I am glad you changed your mind.”

“If this were something I could settle that way, I’d have bought a ticket to Paris already. To hell with international crime.”

“That is true. If Odin Guild disappeared, another Odin Guild would take its place.”

It was the same as when Ares Guild had been our enemy.

The world was vast, and another enemy would fill the space left by the one we defeated. We’d taken Ares Guild by siege; others could do the same to us. Now the City Lord’s duty was to defend the castle from the competitors swarming around it and expand his territory as far as he could.

And Odin Guild wasn’t some stray wolf that had wandered in from who knew where.

It was a beast with a massive body and sharp claws.

A greedy one, too, judging by what was written on the tablet Team Leader Choi had just put in front of me.

“What is this…?”

“The proposal the Chinese government sent Odin Guild during the Monster Wave in Sichuan Province, inviting them to participate. It was unofficial, of course, and had no legal force.”

An unofficial proposal.

I wondered how Team Leader Choi had obtained something that should have been nearly impossible to leak. Then the answer came to me.

“Grandpa Jongseok gave it to you?”

“Not Grandpa Jongseok. Chairman Xiao Yang.”

“Right. Grandpa Jongseok.”

“…”

“What? It sounds friendly. Besides, the old guy likes me a lot.”

Team Leader Choi looked at me as though he’d half given up.

“As you know, Mr. Jin Taekyung, during the early stages of the crisis, China’s State Council and Politburo Standing Committee were reluctant to request help from abroad. They were especially vehemently opposed to support from the West.”

The Skeleton King, still tenderly stroking his skull, interrupted with a puzzled look.

“They opposed it? Why?”

Well, why indeed?

There were any number of reasons, but they all came down to one answer. I kindly gave it to him.

“Because it’s China.”

“What does that mean? Humans are dying either way!”

“Because it’s China.”

“No, treacherous human. You seem not to have understood my question…”

“Yeah. China.”

“…?”

“That’s just how it is. You might not get it yet.”

I left the Skeleton King looking thoroughly confused and turned back to Team Leader Choi.

“But China did ask the West for help eventually, didn’t it? Prince Felix of the United Kingdom and Magic Johnson came, too.”

“Yes. Once the damage from the Arch Lich reached astronomical proportions, China’s leaders had no choice but to accept Chairman Xiao Yang’s argument. They would have to pay a suitable diplomatic and material price when it was over, though, so they had to consider that when assembling their forces.”

That was how four S-rank Hunters had gathered, not counting me.

An incredible force in its own right. But what mattered now was that Odin Guild had backed out when it should have been a central part of that force alongside Lee Jungryong’s Ares Guild.

“Then why did Odin Guild turn down the offer? That looks like enough money to make them accept. More than enough.”

The fee listed on the tablet was staggering—nearly twice what I’d heard Ares Guild had been paid, with several other perks attached. China had offered top-tier treatment befitting the name Odin.

Team Leader Choi’s next words answered my question.

“The Chinese government was the one that ultimately turned it down.”

“What?”

“Odin Guild added a condition when the negotiations were almost complete.”

“What condition…?”

Team Leader Choi took a sip of lukewarm coffee, then spoke quietly.

“They wanted China to lease ten cities—including Chengdu, Meishan, Ziyang, and Suining, the representative administrative districts of Sichuan Province—to Odin Guild for the next ninety-nine years, as well as authorize the establishment of an official branch in Beijing.”

"…!"

"They were effectively asking China to cede Sichuan Province. Permission to set up an official branch, which the Chinese government prohibits, was an added bonus."

Good God. What did I just hear?

I stared at him and muttered, "Wow. Those bastards are insane. They're worse than Chinks."

"According to Chairman Xiao Yang, Odin Guild had contacted the French government shortly before the negotiations."

"Even so, how could they make an offer that crazy?"

"It is France."

"No, there's such a thing as common sense."

"France."

"…Team Leader Choi?"

"France."

"…"

Why did this feel oddly familiar? Was it just me?

As I stared at him with a sour expression, Team Leader Choi spoke to me in a gentle voice.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, did you know Koreans have another name for the French?"

"Oh."

With a sudden flash of insight, I let out an exclamation.

"European Chinks…!"

Team Leader Choi nodded.

"Their skin color and culture are different, but they are the same sort. The President can have an affair or do whatever else he likes, and the French do not care. Odin Guild did not put its headquarters in Paris by accident. Scandals there cause little commotion."

"But wasn't that just an internet meme?"

"I remember my school days in Paris. When a photograph of my maternal grandfather appeared in our history textbook, everyone in the classroom looked at me and pulled their eyes into slits."

"Oh."

"The teacher did it, too."

"Ah! Ah…"

"It is all right. It was a long time ago."

Team Leader Choi set aside the painful childhood memory that had surfaced and continued.

"What matters most is that even with the French government behind it, Odin Guild cannot move against us openly. As with their assassination of Wu Xueming's family, they can only send a warning rather than threaten us directly."

He was right.

Cheon Taemin's flag flew over the walls of Ares Guild, and the world couldn't simply ignore what it had seen me do. That held true even for Odin Guild, the greatest Guild in the world, or any other major Guild.

And above all…

"People around the world are cheering us on. The media may not be able to openly criticize the major Guilds, but plenty of people are condemning them."

Public sentiment.

The strongest weapon—and shield—we had gained by releasing the Mana Cultivation Method.

We needed to make full use of it. Make sure even Odin Guild couldn't come near us…

"Um, sorry to ruin the mood."

The Skeleton King suddenly held out his smartphone.

"Is this the cheering you mean?"

On the screen of the smartphone he offered me was a breaking-news alert that had been posted only a few dozen seconds earlier.

> **Odin Guild Announces Support for Ares**
> **Odin Guild Unveils New Mana Cultivation Method**
> **Senior Official: "A Project We've Been Preparing for Years"**
> **"Though We're a Step Behind, We Want to Change the World with Them." The World's Greatest Guild Shows Its Class**

Fuck. What the hell is this now?

Chapter 735

A middle-aged man in a thin silk robe gazed out the window.

Clouds carrying January's chill swept past, so close he could almost touch them. Far below, he could make out buildings and plazas laid out in separate districts.

A great city steeped in history. Countless people moved through it, reduced to tiny dots.

The gloomy gray sky and mist-shrouded streets hardly suited Paris's name, the City of Light. But the middle-aged man didn't care.

He loved everything about this city—about Paris.

From a skyscraper too high for even the mist to reach, the world was always beautiful.

Especially on a day like today.

Ding. Deeeeng—

Bells rang out across the plaza, announcing seven in the morning. The middle-aged man turned slowly from the wall of windows.

Behind him lay a vast study.

At the round table in its center, over ten figures waited for him, appearing amid the green glow unique to holograms.

"It's been a long time since we all gathered like this. Our last meeting was, what… three years ago?"

The corners of the people's mouths, visible beneath their masks, curled slightly at the joke the middle-aged man made as soon as he took the seat of honor.

Three years?

They had held a secret meeting just two nights ago.

"If I remember correctly, it was ten years ago."

"Ten years? Already?"

"Wasn't it closer to thirty?"

"Damn it. Thirty years ago was the Great Cataclysm. I don't even want to remember the hell we went through, so drop it."

Quiet laughter mingled with their conversation.

The middle-aged man watched them with a gentle smile.

"You all seem to be in good spirits. Yes, it's nice to indulge in idle chatter now and then."

"…!"

"…!"

Silence fell at his quiet words.

They all closed their mouths at once, as though on cue. Still smiling, the middle-aged man went on.

“I did not call this meeting to listen to pointless nonsense or trashy small talk like this… What does everyone think?”

Their eyes wavered at each breath he took, each slight movement of his fingertips.

Even through a hologram, his overwhelming presence—and his aura—reached them.

Everyone at the meeting was a major figure. None could hope to rival him.

The reason was simple.

The man before them was the master of Odin Guild, known as the greatest Guild in the world, and one of the absolute beings capable of controlling the world.

“I-I apologize, Michael. I was pleased that everything was proceeding without a hitch, and…”

“I wasn’t asking for excuses.”

Michael cut him off.

“I simply found it pathetic to see you all relaxing as though everything were over.”

“…”

“Our opponent is more daring than we expected. How else could they have done something so insane?”

No one at the table needed to ask what he meant. By now, the whole world knew.

The public release of the Mana Cultivation Method.

To a tiny number of people, it was an act of madness that threatened to overturn the established order. Their opponent had made it happen anyway.

“I sent Huginn, and they still didn’t get the message. Reckless beyond belief… but I suppose that means they’re confident.”

One of them spoke cautiously.

“If, hypothetically, they’re counting on Sky…”

“I believe I already told you not to concern yourselves with him.”

“…Understood.”

The reply lacked conviction.

Until now, Michael’s word had been law to all of them.

Once he had spoken with such certainty, they had no choice but to dig a hole for any lingering doubts deep in their hearts and bury them there.

But this time, none of them could stop turning the question over.

Because the person in question was none other than Cheon Taemin.

Even so, how can he tell us not to worry about something this serious?

What happens if Sky gets involved?

Where did he get his information…?

The questions kept circling through their minds.

Michael's information had always been reliable. No one knew who provided it or what methods he used to obtain it, but as long as they trusted and acted on the information he brought them, they profited.

Immense wealth and fame. Lofty social status.

Yet even the highest, strongest wall could fall in an instant.

And the name Cheon Taemin was not something they could simply bury through faith. The sense of crisis they felt was conveyed in its entirety to one person.

Tap. Tap.

A finger drummed slowly on the round table. Waves of powerful mana rolled over them, pulling them from their thoughts.

"You seem uneasy."

They hurried to answer his gentle voice.

"Not at all."

"How could we be?"

"Our alliance is powerful. We won't lose to brats like them."

They kept the qualification to themselves: *As long as Cheon Taemin stays out of it.*

For now, they could only trust Michael. Judging by the power and ability he had shown them all this time, those mere fledglings would not be opponents at all, just as one of them had said.

"Choi, that young man, is resourceful, but his limitations are equally clear."

"The same goes for Jin Taekyung. However strong he is, he can't get past the walls we've built."

There had certainly been a time when such a thing was possible.

A time so cruel and chaotic that it could only be called the Great Cataclysm.

Humans slaughtered monsters. Monsters slaughtered humans. And humans slaughtered other humans like livestock.

It was a turbulent period when nothing seemed strange, no matter what happened.

But the Great Cataclysm was over.

On a sea lashed by storms, nothing that happened would seem strange. But in a peaceful world like this one, a mere ripple could not bring about change.

The Mana Cultivation Method they had released was no different.

"Their decision to make the Mana Cultivation Method public has cost us dearly. But we've dealt with the immediate crisis. There's no reason to worry."

"Exactly. The media didn't dare criticize us, and above all, you acted quickly, Guild Master."

Michael nodded without a word.

News of the Mana Cultivation Method Odin Guild had unveiled at sunrise was even now spreading across the world through every kind of media.

Public criticism of the established major Guilds would gradually die down. And the fledglings who had ignored his generous offer would soon regret it.

This time, he would not settle for words. He would show them directly through his actions.

How foolish.

Michael muttered inwardly.

In today's world, a Mana Cultivation Method was a treasure beyond price. A Guild's standing and a nation's influence depended on the strength of their Hunters, yet those fools had given one away to the entire world.

They should have asked themselves why no one had ever done it before.

Others had stepped forward in the past, armed with nothing but morality and a sense of justice. Powerful people recognized around the world, they had wanted to share their special abilities with everyone.

That was why they had died.

And this time will end the same way.

History repeated itself.

Although the Mana Cultivation Method had been made public because of their opponent's unexpected and impulsive act, they would have to pay the price for their foolishness.

That was how the world worked.

There was only one thing that continued to bother him: the young man who had caused the greatest change in recent times.

Jin Taekyung.

Unlike Choi Minwoo, whom Michael still considered a fledgling, that bastard was a powerful figure no one could deny.

In less than a year, he had amassed countless achievements and considerable fame. Recently, he had brought down Ares Guild's headquarters single-handedly, despite the hundreds of Hunters waiting there, Go Jun among them.

And that was not all.

The world didn't know it yet, but Michael knew Jin Taekyung had recently wiped out terrorist organizations and rebel groups.

Power that ranks among the best even among S-rank Hunters. And daring.

Not one of the people chattering before him could match that.

An S-rank Hunter who led a major Guild known around the world. A politician who could sway a powerful nation. A tycoon who owned hundreds of Gates and oil fields…

Every one of them deserved to be called a major figure. To Michael, they were all greedy idiots.

Of course, they're the reason I was able to make Odin Guild the greatest in the world.

Michael muttered inwardly and clicked his tongue softly.

Tsk.

The chatter stopped. Every eye turned to him.

He looked over them one by one. Then he sensed someone approaching from a distance.

"It seems we have a guest."

"Ah, then…"

"I will notify you separately about the next meeting."

Bzzzt.

That was all.

The instant Michael spoke, the holograms melted away and disappeared. At the same time, the study's tightly closed doors swung wide open at a gesture from him.

"So, did you enjoy your trip?"

The man in old-fashioned clothes answered Michael's waiting question.

"I was merely following orders."

"You're always so stiff. Come in, Huginn."

"Thank you."

Thud.

Huginn took off his hat, gave it a few taps, and stepped into the study.

Michael saw grains of sand scattered near the door and smiled calmly.

"You've been getting around."

"The schedule was rather tight."

"You went a long way. It must have been difficult. Did you encounter any problems?"

"There were some, but I took care of them."

His answer was curt, but the heat in Huginn's eyes still held traces of battle.

Michael nodded without showing any particular reaction.

He had personally selected and trained Huginn. As a fixer, the man was without equal, and he carried out every assignment perfectly.

This one included.

"Did you bring your friends?"

"Yes. When they heard why I'd come, they volunteered to help. Unlike the reception I got in Korea, everyone treated me kindly."

"How good of them to come all that way. Where are they now?"

"They should all be on their way to their destinations."

“And the gifts?”

“I made certain they were handed over.”

Huginn drew a pocket watch from his coat and checked it.

“There is about an hour left until the first gift is delivered.”

“An hour. Good. Coffee while we wait?”

“If possible, I would prefer black tea.”

Michael smiled and made them a cup of each.

Exactly one hour later, he confirmed with his own eyes that his orders had been carried out without fail.

BOOOOM!

Beneath the pale clouds, red flames surged upward with a deafening roar. And then…

Whooosh!

The air slowly began to warp. Michael watched it and murmured lightly,

“As expected, it is a beautiful city.”

A building was engulfed in flames.

With Ares Guild’s Paris branch at its center, space began to tear apart.

Chapter 736

It started with barely a tremor. Nothing more, nothing less.

But that was only the first sign.

Rumble…

The ground shook.

Visitors lined up outside the Louvre ducked instinctively. In Paris's 10th arrondissement, people who had been fighting with fistfuls of each other's collars broke apart and scattered, swearing as they ran.

And in the 6th arrondissement…

"Ah…"

People forgot to scream. They could only stare, dazed, at the sight before them.

Gooooom.

Crimson-black darkness coiled around a skyscraper that rose to a dizzying height, then surged upward.

Everyone held their breath at the vast, ominous energy, unlike anything they had ever felt.

BOOOOOM!

The skyscraper that had housed Ares Guild's Paris branch exploded.

The layers of defensive Magic around its exterior. The sturdy frame built to withstand a missile strike. All of it shattered and burst outward.

Fragments large and small, once part of a building some fifty stories tall, rained down in flames.

Fwoosh. Whooooooosh!

"…!"

It was impossible to believe. Impossible to deny.

As countless fragments blotted out the sky, a thought came to the people below.

Maybe today is the day of the apocalypse described in the Bible.

Then they saw the air twisting out of shape, and suspicion hardened into despairing certainty.

Fwooooooosh!

None of them had ever seen it happen. But as people living amid the brightest civilization in history, they knew what the phenomenon was called.

"Monster Wave…"

The words escaped someone like a groan.

Yet even with debris falling toward them and monsters emerging from the warped space, no one ran.

Not the Sorbonne students cycling to class. Not the young couple walking through the Luxembourg Gardens with a stroller. Not the police rushing to calm the public.

Everyone who had been going about their morning—the entire 6th arrondissement—froze where they stood, gripped by fear and a chill that sank into their bones.

And then—

BOOM! BOOM! BOOM!

A rain of fire engulfed everything within a radius of over a hundred meters,[3049] and the gates of hell opened.

Thud. Thud.

Huge monsters with arms and legs as thick as temple pillars, each with two heads on a single body, beat their chests and roared.

—Gwooooooar!

Crash!

Glass shattered all around them, unable to withstand the force of their roars.

Fear, which only powerful monsters could emit, shot out like invisible ropes and bound thousands of people in place.

—Grrrr.

A growl rich with satisfaction.

The hunt was about to begin.

Or so it should have been.

Whooooooosh! Boom!

A flash struck the monster at the front, sending it staggering. Everything above its shoulders was gone.

Thud!

The ground shook. The hundred or so monsters raised their heads as one.

Among the thousands of people rooted to the spot, predators hidden in the flock of sheep were revealing themselves.

They came with dazzling flashes too fast for the eye to follow.

Whooooooosh! Crack!

Rattle, rattle.

Flesh and bone crumpled. Blue blood sprayed in every direction.

A Twin Head Ogre that had survived at the cost of one of its heads stepped backward without realizing it.

It had no idea what waited behind it.

Crunch!

A gigantic fist burst its remaining head like a watermelon.

[3049] A hundred meters is about 330 ft.

The giant possessed strength and a physique far beyond those of the other ogres. It licked its subordinate's brain matter from its fist, and a golden-eyed human was reflected in its enormous pupils.

—Karsh. Marto.

The words were in the Demon Realm language. They sounded almost like a curse.

Huginn paid them no attention. He turned and bowed politely to someone behind him.

"It is a Named Monster—a Giant Ogre. What would you like to do?"

A calm voice answered.

"Not bad. This should do for a demonstration."

"Then…?"

"I'll take it. Clear out the rest."

That was all.

At the order, Huginn and a hundred Hunters swept forward as one, like the storm and lightning painted on their armor.

Like the ancient god whose name they bore: Odin.

Whooooooosh! Slash!

A clash. Then a slaughter.

Limbs as thick as logs flew through the air, and dazzling aura cut through the magical power surging around the monsters.

It was a scene out of myth.

And even in a myth crowded with figures, there was always one hero who shone above the rest.

—Gwooooooar!

Crack!

One Strike.

The roar that had seemed ready to swallow the city fell silent.

Ruuuuumble!

The Giant Ogre, dozens of meters[3050] tall, dropped to its knees before a human who looked tiny beside its mountain of a body.

But to the people who had seen it all, that human was anything but small.

A hero had protected them. A true giant stood before them.

Brought back from the brink of death, the crowd cried out the hero's name—or the heroes' names—as one.

"Michael! Michael!"

"Odin Guild!"

[3050] Dozens of meters means roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–300 ft.

As the cheers spread like wildfire, Michael declared in a ringing voice, “Rest assured. As long as Odin Guild and I are here to protect you, no danger will come to you.”

Then he looked toward the ruins beneath the heaps of concrete and added, too quietly for anyone to hear, “At least not today.”

With a faint smile, he stepped toward the remaining monsters, trampling the fallen name *Ares* beneath his foot. The letters had lost their shine when they tore free of the building and fell among the rubble.

Odin Guild Declares Support for Ares

Odin Guild Master Michael Silbert: “We Offer Our Heartfelt Applause for Ares Guild’s Actions in the Public Interest and Will Walk Forward Alongside Them”

Odin Guild Makes Surprise Release of New Mana Cultivation Method!

Senior Odin Guild Official Dismisses Pre-Release Controversy: “A Major Project Years in the Making. If You Think We Released It Because of Public Opinion, That Is Regrettable, but We Will Endure It…”

The breaking news I’d learned from the Skeleton King early that morning had been startling enough.

Before the shock could fade, another wave hit us.

A far bigger, more terrifying one.

Bzzzt. Bzzzt.

Team Leader Choi’s smartphone vibrated on the table.

A few seconds later, another breaking report came over the holographic TV. It was hard to believe.

—A Monster Wave has occurred in Paris, France. The site is a skyscraper in the city’s 6th arrondissement, now identified as Ares Guild’s Paris branch, in a shocking development…

—The French government has begun sealing off the 6th arrondissement under international emergency law. The casualty count and details of the operation to suppress the monsters remain unknown…

—Local witnesses say Odin Guild, based nearby, was the first to head to the scene…

Reports poured from the TVs around the restaurant.

But among the countless words spilling from the lips of people with different skin colors and speaking different languages, only three terms pierced my ears.

Monster Wave.

Ares Guild’s Paris branch.

And…

Odin.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A sudden Quest, The Darkness Over Paris, has been generated!
You cannot choose whether to accept this Quest. By the authority of the System, the Quest will proceed by force!
Quest
The Darkness Over Paris
Every choice has consequences.
Your enemies have brought down Ares Guild's Paris branch, and the city once full of life is now shrouded in darkness and the roars of monsters.
Rescue them as quickly as possible and repel the monster army to prevent innocent casualties!
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission:
Rescue the survivors of the Paris branch (Incomplete)
Suppress the Monster Wave (Incomplete)
Reward: Determined by the outcome
Failure: Determined by the outcome

"…!"

Everything came at once: the System notification ringing in my ears, the holographic windows appearing before my eyes.

But by the time I saw and heard them, I was already moving on instinct.

No. We all were.

"Gather around me. Quickly!"

Team Leader Choi shouted, pulled a Magic Scroll from his coat, and tore it.

Fwoosh!

A blinding flash burst out and enveloped us.

If I can't come help and you need to get somewhere fast, use this. As long as you know the exact coordinates, you'll arrive safely.

Magic Johnson had said that when he gave me the Magic Scrolls several weeks ago, near the end of the Middle East cleanup operation.

Now we were burning through the several dozen Teleport scrolls he'd given me, one every few seconds.

Rip!

The tough, specially treated parchment tore. The mana dormant inside it awakened, and another brilliant flash enveloped us and carried us toward the chosen coordinates.

Flash!

Light flared again and again.

We leaped through space without pause—sometimes tens of kilometers,[3051] sometimes hundreds.[3052] Before long, my body began to ache, and exhaustion weighed on my mind.

Hup.

The rapid succession of spatial-transit spells was taking its toll.

But no one stopped. Not even Team Leader Choi, who was probably bearing the worst of it.

Grind.

He clenched his teeth and pulled out another scroll.

Ignoring the foreign airport Hunters thrown into confusion by our unauthorized spatial movement, he tore one scroll, then another before the aftereffects of the first had even faded.

Scroll after scroll ripped apart.

With every flash, the scenery changed. So did the skin colors and languages of the people around us.

At last, after a flash I had long since lost count of, we saw it.

The ruins of what had been Ares Guild’s Paris branch.

Huge monster corpses lay scattered everywhere. Amid the concrete and rebar, I could not sense so much as a trace of life.

Then a sound only I could hear cut through the air.

Beep.

[3051] Tens of kilometers means roughly 20–90 km, or about 12–56 mi.

[3052] Hundreds of kilometers means roughly 100–900 km, or about 62–560 mi.

SYSTEM

You have not completed a single mission.
The sudden Quest, The Darkness Over Paris, has failed.
Every event brings both reward and cost. You will receive penalties for failing the Quest.
EXP decreases drastically.
Fame decreases drastically.
The special Title Idle Bystander will apply for the next 30 days.
Due to the penalty effect of the special Title Idle Bystander, all stats decrease by 10%.

"…Ah."

A small sound escaped me.

Quest failure? A massive penalty?

None of that mattered.

Neither did the murmurs of the people who had belatedly noticed us, or the group making its way across the ruins.

Of all the holographic windows floating before me, my senses fixed on one line.

SYSTEM

You have not completed a single mission.

That was all.

The cold, rigid sentence bored through my eyes and into my mind. I already knew what it meant.

They're dead. All of them.

That was the reality before me.

Ares Guild's Paris branch no longer existed. Neither did the people who had begun their day peacefully nearby.

The skyscraper that had once reached the clouds had become a ruin blanketed in death, and the people who had been laughing and talking here only a few dozen minutes ago had crossed a river from which they could never return.

Like the unidentified body buried beneath the wreckage in front of me.

What was I thinking?

I stared down at it, then reached out and grabbed an arm. Only when I pulled did I realize the arm belonged to another body.

That wasn't the end.

When I dragged one body free, I found three more. When I pulled those out, severed limbs emerged beneath them.

“H-how…”

“Wicked human. This… this is truly…”

Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King sounded impossibly far away. I looked around without a word.

The streets around the former branch had been devastated. Acrid smoke rose, carrying the smell of burning flesh. Bodies not yet recovered lay everywhere.

How many more lay beneath the rubble under my feet?

And why?

Why did they have to die?

My stomach burned as though I’d swallowed a ball of fire.

I clenched my teeth until they felt ready to break. Swallowing the blood from my split lips, I struggled to calm the three jiazi[3053] of Scorching Yang Qi raging in my dantian.

I could not get any more agitated. I had to remain calm and composed—more than ever.

Otherwise, I wouldn’t be able to face the owner of the immense energy approaching behind me in my right mind.

Michael Silbert.

With his name in my thoughts, I slowly turned around.

[3053] A *jiazi* is one sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar; three jiazi equal 180 years.

Chapter 737

Michael Silbert.

Anyone living in the modern world knew his name.

He was the Guild Master of Odin Guild, called the greatest in the world, and an extraordinary figure even among the countless heroes born from the Great Cataclysm.

People loved Michael Silbert for risking his life to save them. I had admired him too.

No. I *used* to admire him.

Step.

Footsteps stopped behind me.

I turned slowly. A man stood amid the heat-soaked ash and ruins, gazing at me.

“So, it’s you.”

A few words broke the silence, but they were enough. We had recognized each other. Even without the photographs of him plastered across every kind of media, we would have known.

This is…

I could feel it: the immense power compressed inside that neither-large-nor-small body. It was more powerful than Lee Jungryong’s—or rather, more powerful than any S-rank Hunter I had ever faced.

And that was not all I realized.

“…So it was you?”

Michael Silbert.

The moment I met his gray eyes, I knew whose work the ruins beneath my feet were. I knew who had started this terrible disaster.

My question echoed his first words, but it meant something very different. Michael answered calmly.

“What a pointless question. If it wasn’t me, who else could it be?”

“What?”

“It’s an obvious and trite story anyway. There’s no point in asking or answering anything more.”

What was this?

What the hell was this bastard talking about?

For a moment, I forgot my anger and stood frozen. Michael blinked at me, looking genuinely puzzled.

“I don’t understand why you look so surprised. We already understand each other’s intentions, and now that negotiations have broken down, this is merely the inevitable next step.”

"You son of a—"

"Didn't I warn you through Huginn? Refuse my proposal, and there would be a price to pay."

He cut me off as though none of this mattered. Then Michael Silbert—the hero of the Great Cataclysm, beloved the world over—reached out and caught a handful of ash drifting through the air.

"I hear you've been rather busy these past few weeks. Were you wandering that vast desert looking for an oasis?"

"…!"

"A word of advice. There's no such thing as a perfect secret. Not even at the Pentagon."

He opened his fist. Ash mixed with monster blood lay in his palm, calling up a sight I had witnessed countless times a few weeks ago.

Fanatics dying in droves all around me. Their screams. Grains of desert sand made sticky with blood flowing like a river…

Through those memories, his low voice reached me.

"If you wanted a peaceful, better world, you should have uprooted them completely from the start."

"…You don't mean—"

"Considering they were deranged fanatics, it was a perfectly reasonable deal. I wanted a price paid for ignoring my warning. They wanted weapons for revenge."

Now I understood.

The real cause of this sudden Monster Wave. Why the madman in front of me could admit to it so openly.

Borrow another's knife to kill.

The instant it all fell into place—

Fwoosh.

My vision burned hot. Three jiazi[3054] of Scorching Yang Qi surged from my dantian, transformed into lava, and flowed through my limbs and bones.

I was ready. From the moment I had first faced him, my mind had been searching without pause for the best way to move.

One step.

That was all it would take. The instant I planted my foot, the distance between us would vanish. Then I could shut that bullshit-spouting mouth with my Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

No. I *had* to.

For the innocent people killed by another human being, not a monster. And to remove the cause of an even greater disaster before it struck.

[3054] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi are 180 years.

But—

Grab.

Two hands seized my shoulders, and a familiar voice struck my ears.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung!”

“People are watching. Not now.”

Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King.

They had to be holding back their own anger. As I thought of them, the fury boiling inside me began to settle.

I knew they were right. Attacking the bastard in front of me would be easy. Dealing with what came afterward would be difficult, even for me.

I have no evidence. Nothing that would convince the public I’m justified.

To the rest of the world, Michael Silbert was a hero of the Great Cataclysm who had defeated a terrorist bent on revenge. Whether or not I could kill him, attacking him here would get me branded a public enemy—even if this were Murim rather than the modern world.

And that was probably…

Exactly what he wants.

Cheon Taemin, the beginning and end of Ares Guild, had been unconscious for some time. What would happen if I fell now?

Even if I killed him here, I couldn’t take responsibility for what followed.

Our greatest enemy stood before me, but there were others who had yet to show themselves.

By the time I reached that thought, both my head and my heart had gone cold.

Hssss.

The aura I had built up, ready to burst, subsided. Michael Silbert sighed softly.

“What a shame. You looked much better when you were full of youthful fire.”

“Shut up before I tear your mouth apart.”

“If it were that easy to tear my mouth apart, someone would have done it hundreds of times by now. But do you know something?”

A faint smile touched his lips.

“One day, I noticed that everyone who had said something like that to me had vanished without a trace. I know a more certain way of dealing with them than tearing their mouths apart.”

“…!”

“So be grateful you have good friends today. You’re lucky they’re so capable, too. Wouldn’t you agree?”

He was speaking to me, but he was looking past my shoulder.

That strange look brought my dulled sense of danger snapping back.

The Skeleton King.

Magic Johnson had given him a clean new identity, and he was working as a Hunter with Peace Guild. Even so, it would be a problem if he drew the wrong kind of attention.

Michael Silbert was that difficult an opponent. The moment a weakness appeared, he would pounce without mercy and tear into it.

Should I have left him behind?

The thought had barely crossed my mind when Michael's attention shifted.

"So you're the young Vice Guild Master of Ares Guild I've heard about. How is your maternal grandfather?"

Team Leader Choi answered in an icy voice.

"He's well. I can't say how he'll react when I tell him what happened to the Paris branch."

"I regret how things turned out myself. I have great respect for your grandfather. I hope you'll put in a good word for me."

"I certainly intend to tell him exactly what I saw and heard."

There was not a trace of hesitation in his answer. Michael Silbert was gazing at Team Leader Choi when—

Whoosh! Whoosh!

A group raced across the ruins, cutting through the air. At their head was Huginn, the messenger who had visited Ares Guild not long ago.

He spared us a glance, then hurried to Michael and bowed.

"Guild Master, everything is ready."

"The casualty count first."

"Approximately three hundred. We've rescued forty-five survivors."

"That's enough for now. Have people gathered?"

"Not only the nearby citizens. Every reporter in Paris is waiting for you."

"Faster than I expected."

"We were fortunate. The foreign press was already on alert because of the release of the new Mana Cultivation Method."

"And the CCTV footage?"

"We secured it immediately. It captured everything from beginning to end: the terrorist carrying out a suicide attack with bombs and unrefined Magic Gems, and Odin Guild suppressing the Monster Wave."

At first, I hadn't understood what Huginn meant by *ready*. As I listened, my mind went cold.

This is…

Meticulous.

The unveiling of a new Mana Cultivation Method. The attack on the Paris branch and the Monster Wave, carried out by a Middle Eastern terrorist seeking revenge. Now a press conference with the world's attention on it.

Dozens of gears, large and small, meshing without a fraction of an inch out of place. Every part of their plan was moving as intended.

That was why they could discuss it openly in front of us. They knew we had no way to stop the gears once they were turning.

Even if we shouted the truth for three days and three nights in front of the countless cameras camped out in the distance, no one would believe us anyway.

The worst part was that those madmen were right. Force alone could not change that reality.

"I'm sorry, but I must be going. A great many people are waiting for me."

Michael Silbert acknowledged me, Team Leader Choi, and finally the Skeleton King with a glance before slowly turning away.

Then he stopped and added, "You'll be busy from now on. Far busier than you expect."

Grind.

I watched him walk away, clenching my fist with all my strength. But I could not bring myself to strike.

Not long afterward, I understood what he meant.

Ding.

SYSTEM

A sudden Quest, Chain of Terror Attacks, has been generated!
You cannot choose whether to accept this Quest. The System will force it to proceed!

It was January. The joy of the New Year had not yet faded.

Winter turned red.

"It has begun."

At Huginn's low voice beside his ear, Michael Silbert calmly asked:

"Where this time?"

"London."

"The old king will be furious."

"Buckingham Palace should be fine. London Bridge will collapse instead."

Michael gave a soft laugh at his subordinate's dry joke.

“Once London is done… eight to go.”

“Yes.”

Huginn had brought ten people back from the desert. Every one of them was a deranged fanatic and a seasoned Hunter. They would carry out their missions without a hitch.

Their bombs would bring down buildings. Their unrefined Magic Gems would be enough to shatter people’s hopes.

And our Odin Guild will piece that shattered hope back together.

Everything was ready.

He had reached this position through countless sacrifices and effort.

He could tolerate neither a single mistake nor failure.

As the reporters drew closer and the citizens’ cheers reached him, Michael hid his smile behind a grief-stricken expression.

Chapter 738

There was a strange magic in the words *New Year*.

The excitement of beginning another year. The vague hope that things would be better than they had been the year before.

But one day in January, before people had even turned the first page of their new calendars, that excitement and hope collapsed in an instant.

“Breaking news. Just one hour after our report from Paris, a second Monster Wave has struck London, United Kingdom. Central London is in chaos, and King Philip II of the United Kingdom has…”

“More breaking news! Another Monster Wave has struck Mumbai, India! This is the third Monster Wave in a single day, something unprecedented since the Great Cataclysm…”

“Oh my God. Can you see this? Rio de Janeiro’s landmark, Christ the Redeemer—Cristo Redentor—is falling!”

It was the beginning of a catastrophe.

First, France’s Luxembourg Gardens were stained with blood. Then London Bridge, which had stood through a long and storied history, collapsed. And Brazil’s colossal statue of Jesus, weighing over six hundred tons[3055], toppled over, crushing buildings and people beneath it.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The ground shook with a deafening roar.

Beyond the flames that surged up from the explosion, those who could barely keep their feet heard something growl.

—Grrr…

Monster Waves.

The name had become synonymous with disaster. Legions of monsters tore through space and swept in every direction like a wave.

—Kraaaargh!

“M-Monsters!”

“Get away!”

“Aaaah!”

Screams filled the forest of skyscrapers that civilization had raised.

Some people fled. Some were seized by monsters, torn apart, and killed. Others raised shining weapons and fought against creatures that did not belong to this world.

“Formation! Don’t retreat!”

[3055]The source uses metric tons. Six hundred metric tons is 600,000 kg, or about 1.32 million lb (about 661 US tons).

“Ranged units, fire!”

Boom! Boom! KABOOM!

Humans and monsters. Monsters and humans.

The two species, incapable of coexisting from the start, charged at one another. The flames that had begun in Paris spread across the world.

[Red Square in Moscow stained with blood by monsters]

[Disaster strikes China once again—the Forbidden City engulfed in flames]

[Five Monster Waves in a single day. Upon hearing the news, Pope Urban VIII says, “O God.”]

[The sixth Monster Wave strikes New York. Wall Street in shock.]

[Tokyo Tower seized by flying monsters. Crashed Air Self-Defense Force aircraft cause secondary damage.]

[Odin Guild Master Michael Silbert, who swiftly suppressed the first Monster Wave, releases CCTV footage obtained in Paris: “This is not merely a disaster. It is clearly a terrorist attack with a purpose.”]

Major cities home to millions—some to more than ten million—were thrown into chaos.

People watched one shocking report after another on their televisions and smartphones, too stunned to speak.

Disaster.

It was the only word for what was happening.

At the same time, the fear spreading like a plague paralyzed people’s reason.

“Hello? You saw the news, right? I’m coming to pick you up from school right now, so…”

“Hey, what are you doing?”

“Can’t you see? Packing my things.”

“What are you talking about? You’ve still got hours before you can leave work.”

“Fuck, does that matter right now? I’m going to make sure my family’s safe.”

“Hey, hey! Manager Kim!”

No one could predict a Monster Wave any more than they could predict a natural disaster. People dropped what they were doing and moved as if in a daze.

Toward the homes where their families waited. Or toward emergency shelters where they might have a slightly better chance of surviving.

Offices emptied, most work and road traffic ground to a halt, and people crowding onto the subways could not put down their phones.

What weighed them down now was an extreme fear and anxiety they could not see.

A Monster Wave might strike right where they stood. They—or someone they loved—might die because of it.

Wheeeeeeeen.

"Temporary state of emergency. This is a temporary state of emergency. Residents living nearby are advised to prepare for any eventuality and proceed to an emergency shelter…"

Countries around the world declared states of emergency at the same time.

Sirens sounded without pause in the streets. Soldiers armed with heavy weapons and Hunters called up on short notice waited tensely for instructions from their governments.

They waited until the sun—or the moon—disappeared from the sky above them, according to each country's time zone.

At last, their governments made another announcement.

"The temporary state of emergency has been lifted."

Only twenty-four hours had passed since the first Monster Wave struck Paris. The disaster that had seemed as if it might last until the end of the world finally ended in Cairo, Egypt.

It left behind a horrifying, unprecedented record: ten Monster Waves in a single day.

Then the hero who had successfully stopped five of them stepped before countless cameras.

"Odin Guild will continue to do its duty as your sword and shield."

Michael Silbert.

As people watched him shed hot tears while mourning the souls of the fallen, they cried along with him.

They cheered for the hero who had saved so many lives, and for Odin Guild.

No—not everyone.

Bang!

More than a dozen holographic televisions crumbled to dust with a deafening crash.

I stared at the empty air where a man's face had appeared only moments ago. Then I suddenly opened my mouth.

"Should I apologize?"

Team Leader Choi shook his head from the nearby sofa.

"It's fine. If you hadn't stepped in, I would have smashed them myself."

He wasn't exaggerating or being polite.

I looked at his clenched fist, white with the force of his grip. Drops of blood fell from it, along with the green monster blood he had not yet wiped away.

Drip. Drip.

The white wool carpet was gradually becoming stained red and green, but no one in the room cared.

Everything around me felt cold and empty.

They got us. Completely.

Ten.

Ten Monster Waves, and we hadn't stopped a single one. No—perhaps it was more accurate to say we *couldn't* have stopped them.

They planned it that way from the start.

It was impossible to stop Monster Waves in major cities thousands, even tens of thousands, of kilometers[3056] apart.

Even if Magic Johnson had been with us, it would have made no difference.

The Monster Waves that occurred today had been planned terrorist attacks from beginning to end—bombs detonating without regard for either time or place.

By the time we heard the news and arrived, all that awaited us were more ruins and more bodies.

There was one slight difference between the Monster Wave in Paris and those that followed: where they struck.

They weren't targeting Ares Guild's overseas branches.

The terrorists working with Michael Silbert had gone to all kinds of places. Tourist attractions packed with crowds. The headquarters of major corporations everyone knew by name.

But more often than anything else, they had targeted branches of major Guilds like Ares.

"Why?"

Team Leader Choi looked up at my abrupt question. I added one word.

"The targets."

That was explanation enough. Team Leader Choi stared into empty space with hollow eyes, then suddenly opened his mouth.

"Isolation."

"Isolation?"

"Yes. Isolating Ares Guild. That must be what Michael Silbert wants."

"But why do it like the Paris branch…?"

I stopped.

Thoughts raced through my tangled mind. Somewhere among them was an answer I had missed.

The Middle Eastern terrorist group.

The men working with Michael Silbert had not finished their mission.

[3056] 1,000 km is about 621 mi; 10,000 km is about 6,214 mi.

The final strike that would bring this horrific day to a close—the keen, ice-cold blade that would isolate Ares Guild from the entire world—was rushing toward us.

Perhaps even now.

Step. Step.

Footsteps echoed unusually loudly through the darkness.

Perhaps it was because there were several dozen people. Perhaps it was because they were crossing a dark cave. One thing, at least, was certain.

No one knew this place existed, and no one could find their way here.

Step.

The footsteps, which had seemed as though they would go on forever, stopped together.

Something stirred in the pitch-black darkness.

“Inshallah.”

The word sounded as though it had been whispered into their ears. Several dozen people dropped to their knees and prostrated themselves.

Then they opened their mouths and answered in unison.

“Inshallah.”

God willing.

It was an invocation that bound them together and a prayer that reminded them of God’s greatness. The figure stirring beyond the darkness finally emerged.

Swish.

A long robe brushed the ground. The people bowed their heads lower and murmured as one.

“This lowly servant of Allah humbly greets the great Prophet.”

The Prophet.

To them, even the title of a being whose face they dared not look upon was sacred and untouchable.

“Raise your heads.”

The voice gave no hint of age or gender. The people trembled.

Then they pressed their faces to the ground and answered.

“How could these lowly servants dare look upon the great Prophet?”

“Please withdraw your command.”

Whoosh.

A gust of wind came from somewhere and enveloped them.

Then the Prophet’s voice, mingled with the wind, reached their ears.

“What became of them?”

Everyone knew whom the Prophet meant.

The old man prostrated at the very front opened his mouth.

“They completed the missions entrusted to them and returned to God’s embrace.”

The Prophet gave a slight nod.

“Inshallah. As was only right.”

“Inshallah.”

Ten warriors had crossed the desert and scattered across the five oceans and six continents. As warriors of God, they had completed their missions and returned to the embrace of God.

Now it was time to claim the blood price.

The Prophet spoke in a mysterious voice.

“Let the whole world know what brought about all this disaster.”

Chapter 739

Ten Monster Waves in a single day were enough to plunge the world into shock and terror.

Worse, they had struck capitals and major cities whose names were known around the world. Several major Guilds, led by Odin Guild, had swiftly suppressed the Monster Waves, but the damage was immense. The confirmed death toll alone had reached several thousand.

People kept their senses on high alert in their homes or emergency shelters, and Michael Silbert did not miss the opportunity to seize the attention of the entire world.

“This is footage Odin Guild obtained during the first Monster Wave in Paris.”

When the CCTV footage was released, it sent another shock through the world.

> **Odin Guild Master Michael Silbert: “Before it became a Monster Wave, this was a meticulously planned terrorist attack.”**

> **Not a natural disaster, but a man-made one**

> **A calamity born of malice**

> **Ten killers armed with bombs and Magic Gems. Who are the suicide terrorists in the released CCTV footage?**

> **Experts analyzing the CCTV footage: “Each carried several unrefined A-grade Magic Gems and targeted areas near Gates with high concentrations of magical power.”**

> **The world shudders at a horrifying déjà vu: “Remember what happened in South Korea.”**

> **Bringing in bombs and unrefined A-grade Magic Gems: a clear violation of international law**

> **Bombs and Magic Gems traced to Africa and the Middle East**

News reports poured in from every direction.

Once it became clear that the Monster Waves had not been unstoppable natural disasters but tragedies caused by terrorism, people were consumed by anger and emptiness, and the internet reached saturation point.

> ㄴ I’ve got no words. These people are seriously insane. ㄴ Are they out of their fucking minds?

> ㄴ The truth must be brought to light. Every last one of them must be hanged.

> ㄴ I saw a foreign article mentioning South Korea. Is that about the Go Jun incident a little while ago? ㄴ Yeah. And now the people who hate Korea are foaming at the mouth, saying Korea’s the root of all evil. ㄴ What the fuck? They wouldn’t even be alive if it weren’t for Cheon Taemin. ㄴ What countries are these people from? ㄴ Jjajang. Wasabi.[3057] ㄴ Oh. ㄴ Japan’s always been like that, but what’s with those Chinese bastards? Have they already forgotten Lord Fuck helped them? ㄴ “China.” ㄴ That one word says it all. ㄴ To be fair, maybe because he helped them before, it’s nowhere near as bad in China as it is in Japan. Some people are even tracing the IQs of commenters insulting Lord Fuck so they can teach them a lesson. ㄴ My IQ’s 110. Can they track my location from that? ㄴ I’ve seen people bashing Korea on foreign forums too. Cheon Taemin and Jin Taekyung worked hard to raise Korea’s standing, and that bastard Go Jun[3058] went and ruined it all. ㄴ Jin Taekyung raised Korea’s standing? You sure? Funny, I haven’t seen him once today wwwwwww. ㄴ Haven’t seen your Air Self-Defense Force since a Wyvern beat the shit out of it, either. I did get a good look at Tokyo Tower collapsing, though. ㄴ Welcome, wasabi. ㄴ Does Lord Fuck have ten bodies, you Japanese bastard? Watch some TV. Taekyung ran himself ragged today. He was a step late, but seeing him try to save even one person somehow really moved me. ㄴ So criticizing Korea automatically makes someone Japanese now, lol? Unfortunately, I’m Korean. ㄴ If you want to keep pretending you’re Korean, take the W key off your keyboard.

> ㄴ There was no point paying attention to trolls. The most important thing now was finding out who the terrorists belonged to and why they had committed such acts. ㄴ The terrorists are all from the Arab world, so it’s

[3057] *Jjajang* and *wasabi* are food-based shorthand used here to refer disparagingly to Chinese and Japanese people.

[3058] The character □, inserted into the Korean spelling of the name, means “the late.”

> obvious. It has to be either Al-Qaeda or IS. ㄴIf it's so obvious, why haven't the countries that were hit issued a joint statement or an official announcement? They need to verify it first. Al-Qaeda and IS have both taken serious losses lately. ㄴI agree with the comment above. A few weeks ago, their main bases were completely wrecked and their leader was killed and replaced.

Everyone knew about the bloodbath that had swept through the Middle East and Africa.

A mysterious group of vigilantes had appeared. No one knew their faces, their names, or even their genders. They had beheaded the leaders of the terrorist and rebel groups. With their leadership gone in an instant, the two factions had torn themselves apart in fierce internal struggles, suffered enormous losses, and finally raised the white flag.

> ㄴDoesn't that make it even more obvious? They may have been weakened, but if they lost their leader, they could easily have carried out terrorist attacks around the world in the name of revenge. ㄴThere are probably a lot of elementary school kids here who don't know this, but when the United States got seriously pissed off during the 9/11 attacks, Hussein got scared and denied that it was them. A little while ago, they practically surrendered and begged people to stop, saying they wouldn't commit any more terrorist attacks. But this terrorist attack involved ten countries, including the United States. Do you really think that makes sense? ㄴNo matter how crazy they are, that's impossible. Besides, I heard the current leaders of the Middle Eastern terrorist groups belong to the moderate faction. ㄴWhat the hell is going on?

Korean netizens were hardly the only ones asking. News sites and online communities around the world lit up with arguments.

Before long, the answer was broadcast worldwide in a video.

"I declare in the name of the Prophet."

In the dim light stood an unidentified figure with a robe pulled low over their face.

In the grainy footage, the figure called themself the Prophet and pointed to the two heads placed in front of them before continuing.

"I will wipe from this sacred land the apostates who abandoned their convictions for their own safety. I will bring rightful vengeance and justice to the world."

It was not hard to recognize whose heads they were. They had led the world's most dangerous terrorist organizations, and only recently had announced a humiliating surrender.

IS. And Al-Qaeda.

Before the horribly beheaded former leaders, the Prophet slowly parted their lips.

“As long as God is with us, we will not stop. Beginning today, we will judge and punish you.”

“…!”

“…!”

The people watching the video caught their breath without realizing it.

Judgment? Today’s horrific tragedy was only the beginning?

Yet even those staring at the screen in disbelief understood it instinctively. The unidentified figure calling themself the Prophet was not making an empty threat. They could set off a bomb anywhere in the world right now and bring about another disaster.

Then the Prophet’s final words reached the stunned audience.

“Inshallah.[3059] Know that all of this began with you.”

Crackle.

The short video ended in a burst of harsh static.

No—just when everyone thought it had ended, another screen began transmitting.

It was a dark night, with even the moonlight faint.

A lone figure standing in a desert filled with blood and corpses suddenly raised their head. The face glimpsed through the mask resembled someone everyone knew.

The Skeleton King crossed an empty corridor.

He held a silver tray in one hand, his eyes fixed on the smartphone in the other.

> **Seven Days Stained with Blood**

> **Monster Wave in Madrid, Spain. Another Terrorist Attack?**

> **The Prophet: Notorious Terrorist Vanishes Like a Ghost**

> **Video Analysis Finds a 99.99% Match: Young Hero’s Other Identity**

[3059] *Inshallah* is Arabic for “if God wills it.”

> **Joguk Ilbo Chief Editorial Writer Lee Kanghee: “A Tragedy Born of Pointless Heroism”**

> **Public Opinion Divided: A Criminal Drunk on Heroism, or a Vigilante in the Shadows?**

“…Damn humans.”

The Skeleton King muttered the curse before he knew it.

Even a brief glance showed him what a mess the online news had become. The front page was filled with nothing but openly condemnatory articles and sensational headlines, while fierce battles between netizens raged beneath them.

> ㄴLol, look at the level of these garbage reporters’ headlines. ㄴSeriously. They’re desperate for clicks. Nothing in the articles, either—just bits and pieces stitched together. ㄴBut if you only look at the headline, it isn’t entirely wrong, is it? ㄴHonestly, I like Lord Fuck too, but I think he acted too hastily this time.

> ㄴThis deserves criticism. There’s nothing he can say for himself. ㄴWhat do you mean? A few weeks ago, when he wrecked Al-Qaeda and the others, you were all cheering. You didn’t know who did it, but you said it felt great to see those bastards wiped out. ㄴThat doesn’t mean it was right. ㄴIt was fine then but not now? You’re fucking nuts, lol. ㄴThe situation has changed. Seriously, how many people are dead now? Nationalist hype and personal fandom are all well and good, but look at how serious the situation has become because of what Jin Taekyung did.

> ㄴI knew that bastard Jin Taekyung would cause trouble. I couldn’t stand watching him get full of himself when everyone started calling him a young hero and the next Cheon Taemin. ㄴWhat a load of shit. When was he ever full of himself? Even when the media was hyping him up, hyung[3060] was still walking around in a tracksuit.

> ㄴI’m trying to stay neutral here, but honestly, it’s just sad. Do you really think Jin Taekyung did it because he’s some bloodthirsty killer? ㄴThen why did he do it? ㄴLook at the timing. It was right before the Mana Cultivation Method was released. Seriously, do you think there are only one or two

[3060] *Hyung* is a Korean term used by a male speaker for an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

> Awakened among the Middle Eastern terrorists and African rebel groups? Who was supposed to deal with them if they learned the Mana Cultivation Method and started committing every kind of crime, including terrorism? ㄴ That still doesn't justify murder. ㄴ You're right. But let's be clear: everyone justified it back then. Now one unbelievably insane bastard has shown up, and everyone's changed their tune at the speed of light. ㄴ People at home and abroad were all praising the vigilantes at the time. "Whoever they are, great job. Let's not ask too many questions." That was the mood. Now it's flipped.

> ㄴ Lot of Jin Taekyung fanboys here, lol. He's still being condemned worldwide. ㄴ Polls show more people support Lord Fuck. It only looks otherwise because the news sites keep churning out sensational headlines.

> ㄴ What I don't get is Cheon Taemin. Even now, he hasn't shown his face once. Jin Taekyung's been missing for days too. ㄴ He caused trouble and is pretending it has nothing to do with him. Seriously disgusting, lol. Just look at Odin Guild. King-God Michael is the past and the future.

Reading the comments, the Skeleton King found himself wondering:

What faces would those humans make if they knew the truth?

But he knew the thought was futile.

At least for now, there was no way to reveal the truth. On the contrary, they might be completely sunk by the backlash.

Human society, as he had come to know it, was far more complicated—and far more frustrating—than he had expected.

Stupid humans.

The Skeleton King shook his head and stopped before a massive door.

When he discovered that the silver tray he had brought yesterday was still sitting there, he let out a deep sigh and carefully pulled on the doorknob.

Click.

As the door slowly opened, he saw someone sitting cross-legged with their back to him.

Chapter 740

Circulating qi did more than increase internal energy.

It cleared away the waste that naturally built up in the body and calmed the mind. And in a state of such deep concentration, all five senses were heightened to their limits.

What's that…?

Step. Step.

Someone's footsteps sounded like thunder.

Before long, I realized who the uninvited guest pacing outside the door was and brought my internal energy under control.

Chime.

The System notification announcing the end of my qi circulation had barely sounded when the doorknob turned behind me.

Click.

A rich scent drifted through the gap as the door eased open. I let out a long breath, bringing everything to a close, and spoke.

"I thought I told everyone to stay out until I came out on my own… Is it because you're a monster that you can't understand human speech? Or do you just not want to?"

The uninvited guest hesitated, then cleared his throat. It was the Skeleton King.

"Ahem. How did you know it was this body?"

"Your presence."

"My presence?"

"Yeah. You don't breathe. Probably because you're already dead."

"…That makes a strange amount of sense, but I don't like it."

"I'm not trying to make you happy."

I pulled on the tracksuit I had tossed aside nearby and turned around. The Skeleton King stood there like a butler, holding a gleaming silver tray.

"So why are you here?"

Normally, he would have been sulking by now, his lips sticking out a good five feet.

But today was different. He kept stealing glances at me as he lowered the tray to the floor.

"Eat. This body brought it here personally for you."

"I told you not to bring me food."

"But you haven't eaten in over three days."

Over three days?

I looked around. The room was sealed on all sides, without so much as a window. I had come in without my smartphone, and whether it was that or the fact that I'd had no mind to care, I'd lost track of time.

Has it been that long already?

Humans were strange. The moment I realized how many days had passed, hunger caught up with me.

But…

Did I even have the right to feel hungry?

Thousands had died. Tens of thousands had been injured. I didn't know what kind of lives they'd led, but most of them must have done nothing wrong.

Those people had suffered because of what I'd done. They'd died, been hurt, lost family and friends they loved.

People who had hailed me as a hero only a short while ago had begun turning against me, one by one. Their condemnation had reached the people around me, too.

All because they were close to me.

What went wrong? Where did it start?

I'd shut myself in this room to answer the question that wouldn't leave my mind. I'd spent each day without food or sleep, circulating qi and turning it over in my thoughts.

At last, I'd found an answer.

Not one that would put everything right. Just an insight that let me forget for a little while.

"Smells good."

"Huh?"

"Not you. The food."

The Skeleton King seemed to buffer for a moment before answering.

"Uh, yeah. It's doenjang jjigae[3061] and braised short ribs."

I could tell who had made it just from the smell. Picturing my mother anxiously preparing meals for me these past few days, I lifted the lid from the tray.

Click.

I stared blankly at the food as steam rose from it. Then I scooped up a spoonful of doenjang jjigae[3062], something I had not seen in a long time.

The moment I put it in my mouth, I spat it right back out.

Ptooey.

"Wh—what? Why?"

What the hell was this?

[3061] *Doenjang jjigae* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybean paste.

[3062] *Doenjang jjigae* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybean paste.

I looked back and forth between the flustered Skeleton King and the doenjang jjigae[3063] before opening my mouth hesitantly.

“Who made this?”

“Your younger sister.”

“…Ah. Right.”

“Is something wrong?”

Was something wrong? Yes. Seriously wrong.

But instead of answering, I let out a quiet laugh. I didn’t know why. I just did.

“I’ll eat before I go.”

“What?”

“I said I’ll eat this, then go. I need a shower, too.”

The Skeleton King blinked at me for a while, as if he hadn’t understood. Then he nodded hurriedly.

“Oh? Oh, all right. Then this body will…”

“Yeah. See you later.”

He eased the door shut and slipped away like a thief. Another inexplicable laugh escaped me.

I set down my spoon, picked up a piece of braised short rib, and took a big bite.

Thankfully, my mother had made the ribs.

“There were vicious dogs going around biting people, so I beat them senseless. Now two mad dogs have shown up.”

Those were my first words to Team Leader Choi in days. His lips moved as though he had been about to say something, but he nodded instead.

“That’s right. And those two mad dogs bit even more people.”

“Do you think it’s my fault too, Team Leader Choi?”

“Mad dogs are mad dogs. The timing and the excuse may change, but they would have bared their teeth at people sooner or later.”

“But I’m the one who gave them the opportunity.”

“If you insist on blaming yourself, say *we*. You didn’t do it alone.”

“That’s right. This body also achieved a great feat in the desert.”

At the Skeleton King’s sudden interruption, Team Leader Choi shrugged.

“So he says.”

“I’m not blaming myself. I just think I need to be clear about that much.”

Every incident had a cause and an effect. With so many people dead or injured, I couldn’t pretend I had no part in the cause.

[3063] *Doenjang jjigae* is a Korean stew made with fermented soybean paste.

I had no intention of trying.

“I understand why people condemn me. And I’m grateful to the ones who support me.”

“Is that all?”

“No. The most important part is still left.”

I went on calmly.

“No matter what the world says, I’m going to catch those mad dogs.”

The Skeleton King’s eyes gleamed. A faint smile appeared on Team Leader Choi’s face.

“You found your own answer.”

“It’s not a complete answer. But it’s enough of a reason to keep going, isn’t it?”

“It is. Then I can give you a few pieces of news with a lighter heart.”

“A few pieces of news…?”

“I’d been gathering information on Michael Silbert and Odin Guild since before this happened. I received the results recently.”

Team Leader Choi had been watching the other major Guilds since before the Mana Cultivation Method was released. Given how thorough he was, of course he had.

“What did you find? Good news, I hope.”

“Unfortunately, some of it is bad. Which would you like first?”

“How much worse could things get? Give me the bad news.”

Team Leader Choi gave a short laugh and took a thick stack of documents from a drawer.

“I did my best to organize it, but there’s still an enormous amount.”

“What’s this?”

“Information on Odin Guild’s assets and businesses. Much of it isn’t publicly known.”

“They’re held under other names?”

“Yes. On paper, they have no connection to Odin Guild. In practice, they’re run much like its subsidiaries. Other major Guilds and corporations do the same thing, but Odin’s scale is in another league.”

I knew next to nothing about this sort of thing, but the thickness of the stack told me plenty. I skimmed pages full of words and sentences I could barely understand, searching for a comparison.

“Bigger than Ares Guild?”

“You would have to combine Ares Guild and Peace Guild, then add three or four major Guilds on top of that.”

“Holy shit.”

"Count just the Gates Odin Guild controls this way, and there are more than two hundred worldwide. They hold permanent leases, so they effectively own them. Those Gates produce an enormous quantity of Magic Gems."

Even if a considerable number of those holdings were controlled through unofficial channels, having control of around two hundred Gates put Odin Guild on the level of a small country.

No. Given the strength of its Hunters, it might be more powerful than one.

I wish he were just a mad dog.

Michael Silbert wasn't merely a mad dog. He was a Tosa mastiff among fighting dogs, and he was clever to boot.

But he was also a bastard I absolutely had to beat to death.

That thought brought another to mind.

"Then is it possible that the Magic Gems from those Gates were used in this terrorist attack without being refined?"

"No. At least, not according to the documents."

"According to the documents?"

"As you know, Michael Silbert is an extremely thorough person. He had no reason to take the risk of smuggling Magic Gems, and even if he had, he would not have left any gaps in the records. The Magic Gems used in the terrorist attacks most likely came out of the Middle East or Africa."

That made sense.

The Middle East and Africa had been hotbeds of terrorism and civil war since before the Great Cataclysm. Even now, there were people somewhere in those regions fighting bloody battles.

No one knew exactly how many Magic Gems came out of Gates held by terrorists and rebels, or how many of those Gems remained unrefined.

Besides, Michael Silbert wasn't alone. He had a reliable accomplice who was every bit as much a mad dog.

"The Prophet."

At the name that slipped from my mouth, Team Leader Choi nodded with a grim expression.

"I searched thoroughly for information on the Prophet as well."

"What kind of bastard is the Prophet?"

I genuinely wanted to know who this madman was—the one who had beheaded the leaders of two major terrorist organizations, united their scattered followers, and shaken the world.

Team Leader Choi's answer was nothing like what I'd hoped to hear.

"We don't know."

"You don't know?"

“No. Even allowing for the circumstances, there’s no information about the Prophet at all. He vanished completely after that declaration.”

“Wait. Even the United States doesn’t know?”

“Not just the United States. Even with the entire world searching, the situation is still the same.”

I blinked and thought.

How is that possible?

The madman calling himself the Prophet had thrown the United States and the rest of the world into turmoil. How could he vanish right under everyone’s noses?

“You’re not hiding what you know to protect classified information, are you?”

“I spoke with Chuck Hagel recently. He swore to God he didn’t know where the Prophet was.”

Chuck Hagel had been with us in the desert. He was also the United States Secretary of Defense, not just an S-rank Hunter.

Unless he was lying, if even the Secretary of Defense did not know, then the Prophet really must have shot straight up into the sky.

Who the hell is he?

I frowned. Team Leader Choi went on.

“And there’s one more thing. Mr. Johnson contacted us. He said he had found someone among the other Grand Mages who was likely to have been in contact with Michael Silbert. He said we would probably be able to learn more vital information through that person.”

This, at least, was good news.

I hadn’t heard the Grand Mage’s name yet, but he must know something about Michael Silbert’s true nature. He had personally created Ares Guild’s Area A and knew about Cheon Taemin’s condition.

One of only three Grand Mages in the world. He would give us a new lead.

Or so I thought.

Then, not long afterward, Team Leader Choi’s phone rang. I heard Magic Johnson’s voice.

“Damn it. He’s dead.”

Chapter 741

“Damn it. He’s dead.”

I’d hoped I was wrong.

But the unease I’d felt at those few words over the phone had been right on the mark.

“Sorry, but you need to come right away. We have to find as many clues as we can before this case slips out of our hands…”

“Where are you?”

There was no time to hesitate.

We headed for the coordinates Magic Johnson had given us as fast as we could. After several long-distance Teleports in succession, we arrived on a mountain blanketed in white.

Crunch.

The snow that had lain there for ages crumbled beneath my feet.

The breathtaking scenery of the Alps, something I had only ever seen on the internet, unfolded before my eyes. But I had no time to admire the view.

And neither did—

“Intruders spotted!”

—the group guarding the area nearby.

“Stop! Stop!”

“Shooters, ready!”

Chk-chk-chk!

At the urgent shouts, gun barrels and blades were pointed at us.

The soldiers and Hunters were heavily armed. I stopped, and a familiar voice came from among them.

“If you insist on attacking, I won’t stop you. But it would be in your best interest to check the intruders’ faces first.”

“One more step and we shoot… Mr. Johnson?”

“Don’t act rashly, Colonel. They’re my guests.”

A huge Black man walked past the middle-aged commander in a beret and stopped before us.

Fatigue and sorrow weighed on his face.

Magic Johnson, whom I had not seen for several weeks—no, several months—gave us a faint smile and greeted us.

“Long time no see, friends. How have you been?”

I smacked my lips bitterly and firmly grasped the hand he held out.

“Not well at all.”

“Who are the people outside? It looked like an even split between soldiers and Hunters.”

“Swiss Federal Police. This area’s under their jurisdiction, and I didn’t want to become a murder suspect just because I found the body first. Come on.”

Team Leader Choi, the Skeleton King, and I followed Magic Johnson.

We passed between the soldiers and Hunters watching us with equal parts wariness and curiosity, then entered a forest deep in snow. A faint sense of déjà vu stirred.

This is…

I closed my eyes and focused. As I slowly reached out, I felt an invisible ripple through the fierce snowstorm.

“Mana?”

Magic Johnson nodded.

“A barrier. Concealed well enough that even most S-rank Hunters wouldn’t notice it, and just as flawless as it is discreet.”

He wasn’t exaggerating.

Even the Skeleton King had barely noticed the barrier until Johnson pointed it out.

“Impressive work for a human. But not enough to fool this body’s keen gaze. After all, I am no ordinary S-rank Hunter. I am an exceptionally gifted—”

“Monster.”

“…”

The Skeleton King fell silent, crestfallen.

Having shut him up with one word, I studied the barrier and recalled something from not long ago.

It’s similar.

Just as a particular martial art left behind a specific trace, magic worked the same way.

The flow of mana was as distinctive as a fingerprint. I was sure of it.

No doubt about it. It feels like Area A.

Magic Johnson met my eyes, as if he’d read my mind.

“I’d been looking for people connected to Area A at your request, even before all this happened. But of everyone I know, only one person came to mind.”

I now knew who the Grand Mage who designed Area A was. I also knew he’d announced his retirement more than a decade ago and disappeared from public view.

“I didn’t expect him to be staying in a place like this. But had you been in contact with that person separately?”

“Not at all. He was quite eccentric and reclusive.”

“But we were friends. We were close enough that he could at least give me a hint about the hideout where he planned to stay someday.”

Whoosh.

Mana mingled with mana, and the snowstorm came to a stop amid a flash of pure white light.

No—the scenery had changed.

The vast snowfield was gone. We stood inside an enormous cave, its long passages winding like a maze.

“Follow me. Magic, including spatial movement, can’t be cast inside.”

We talked as we followed him through the cave.

Unsurprisingly, things hadn’t been going smoothly for Magic Johnson either.

“You’ve seen the news, so you know our L.A. branch was hit. It’s on the outskirts of the city, but there’s so much foot traffic around it that we couldn’t prevent casualties.”

Magic Johnson was a Grand Mage and the owner of the vast Wizard Guild.

Although it had been pushed out of the rankings several years ago, the Wizard Guild had once been one of the world’s top ten Guilds, even if only in last place.

Yet neither the Wizard Guild, with its many mages, nor Magic Johnson had been able to stop the planned terrorist attacks that unfolded with lightning speed.

“By the time I got there, it was too late. Afterward, I was swamped dealing with everything else.”

I didn’t ask what had kept him so busy. Everyone here knew.

The so-called “vigilante incident”—our campaign against the Middle Eastern terrorists and African rebel groups.

That campaign had become both the justification for these attacks and the means of carrying them out. Much of the public now blamed us for it. Magic Johnson had been one of the vigilantes, and he couldn’t escape the criticism.

None of us could. I’d simply taken the hardest hit from the media.

“I’m sorry.”

“What?”

“I felt I owed you an apology. If I hadn’t proposed it, the whole world wouldn’t be cursing us out right now…”

“Damn it. Is that what you’re talking about?”

Johnson stopped and shook his head.

“Listen, Jin. This isn’t your fault. You don’t need to apologize to me, either. Understand?”

“Of course, but—”

“Let me ask you something. If you could go back, what would you do? Leave those bastards alone?”

I didn’t need long to think. I’d turned that question over and over in a room where no light could reach me.

“No.”

“What about you two?”

Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King looked at each other, then answered almost at the same time.

“Nothing would change. If anything, I’d make even more certain they were dealt with.”

“This body will kill that bastard called the Prophet without fail.”

“Good. Clear answers.”

Johnson shrugged at their different answers, which amounted to the same thing.

“And I’m saying this just in case, but no matter what people say about that incident, I don’t regret it in the slightest. Chuck Hagel feels the same way, even though he isn’t here right now.”

Chuck Hagel.

I could still picture him beating down terrorists while suffering through cigar withdrawal.

Team Leader Choi had mentioned on the way here that Chuck was facing plenty of trouble himself.

“How’s Chuck doing?”

“Not well.”

“That was quick.”

“Because it’s true. The external and internal pressure coming down on him is tremendous. At this rate, it wouldn’t be strange if he were dismissed from his position as Secretary of Defense before long.”

Team Leader Choi joined in, his voice calm.

“The pressure must be too much for even the President to shield him.”

“Chuck’s situation is different from yours. He’s a high-ranking official—the United States Secretary of Defense. The President may have tacitly approved what we did, but that only protected him while it stayed secret.”

“But the entire world found out. And it was revealed directly by a terrorist of historic proportions called the Prophet.”

“…Yeah. Thanks to some damn traitor.”

The operation had gone ahead with the President’s tacit approval. Our mission as “vigilantes” was never supposed to become public.

That was why I'd dared to act so boldly in the modern world, with all its restrictions. I'd trusted that the satellite surveillance system would be disrupted and every related record destroyed.

But information about us had leaked out in plain sight, and I vividly remembered what Michael Silbert had said amid the ruins of Paris.

I'll give you one piece of advice. There are no perfect secrets in this world. Not even in the Pentagon.

The United States was still the world's most powerful nation, and the Pentagon was its Department of Defense headquarters, reputed to have the tightest security in the country.

Yet information that should have been kept secret even within the Pentagon had made its way out.

So easily.

But…

With him involved, it's no surprise.

I was taking it with a calm that surprised even me.

Because the opponent was Michael Silbert. He was stronger than any Hunter I had ever encountered—and even more insane than he was strong.

And then there was the unidentified madman called the Prophet.

No ordinary person could do this. No person could even try.

Even evil had its degrees.

In that sense, the path those bastards had taken had already crossed the line by an absurd distance.

Thousands were already dead, and more than ten times that number injured.

Not every crime committed throughout the world over the course of the week—including the day the Paris branch collapsed—could have been their doing, but it was obvious that they had exerted a considerable influence.

Fear paralyzed reason and gave rise to another kind of madness.

Along with the ten terrorist attacks accompanied by Monster Waves, the distribution of magical power continued to rise at an even steeper rate, and Mutated Gate phenomena were now occurring dozens of times a day.

Some terrified people were already speaking of the end of the world. With crosses hanging at their waists and microphones in their hands, they shouted about God's mercy at the top of their lungs in the streets.

Just as their parents had done long ago.

But I wasn't looking for God.

Those bastards were only human, not devils, and I was ready to bring them down.

There was only one problem…

The thread leading to one of them had been severed just like that.

As I muttered inwardly, I stopped walking. At some point, the long, winding passage of the cave had come to an end.

And waiting for us at the end was a corpse.

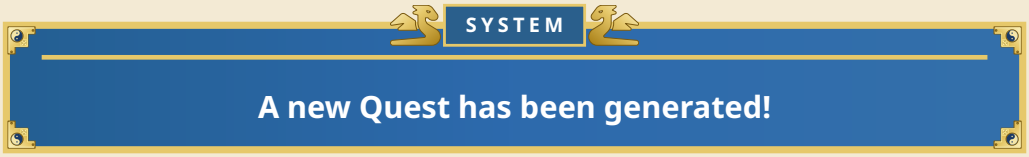
Every bone and scrap of skin on its body had dried up and shriveled tight, like a mummy.

"...What is this?"

Team Leader Choi's voice came out like a groan.

At that moment—

Chime.



The clear chime rang out more ominously than ever.

Chapter 742

SYSTEM

A new Quest has been generated!
An Unexpected Quest, Unknown Death, has been forcibly accepted!
Quest
Unknown Death
The reclusive Grand Mage Siegfried Bassmann has died for an unknown reason.
Yet everything has a cause.
Discover how he died and who killed him.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Reveal the truth behind his death (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

I stared at the Quest window floating in midair.

The name of the deceased in the first line of the description told me that this corpse, which had met such a gruesome end, belonged to one of only three Grand Mages in the entire world.

Siegfried Bassmann.

Siegfried, also known as the “Hero.” The greatest Hunter ever produced by Switzerland, a permanently neutral country, and a Grand Mage with exceptional talent for summoning and barrier magic.

If Magic Johnson was a War Mage who specialized in combat and killing, Siegfried was one of the few scholars who had devoted himself to the study of magic itself.

At least until today, when he was found dead in his own hideout.

“Was he like this when you arrived?”

Magic Johnson nodded, his expression grim.

“Yes. I could hardly believe it myself. I checked several times before I accepted that the body was Siegfried’s.”

“How often did you keep in touch?”

“Once or twice a year after he went into hiding. Even then, I’d have to contact him ten times or so before he answered, and it took him ages. This is my first time here. He was intensely private and hated visits like this.”

“Then the last time you heard from him was…”

“Hmm. About three years ago, I think.”

“Three years. I heard he went into hiding nearly ten years ago.”

"The last time we met, just before he retired, he gave me a communication artifact he'd made himself. Told me to use it if anything was truly urgent."

I took the artifact Magic Johnson pulled from inside his clothes. It was a crystal ball about the size of an adult's fist, and it held a considerable amount of mana—as if to prove a Grand Mage had made it.

Of course. Normal radio signals and communications would have been impossible inside a space surrounded by layers upon layers of barriers. He probably intended it that way.

I'd never met Siegfried Bassmann, but by all accounts he was a shut-in. He avoided attention of any kind, and once a subject caught his interest, he'd dig into it until he'd dissected every last part of it.

"I contacted him every Thanksgiving and Christmas, but he stopped answering three years ago. I knew what he was like, so I let it go. Being called a hero made him uncomfortable, and he hated attention from the press. Even after the Great Cataclysm ended, he'd sometimes disappear into his research for long stretches."

I couldn't make sense of it.

A Grand Mage who had gone into hiding to escape the public eye had died like this in his own refuge.

One thing, though, was certain.

"This wasn't an ordinary natural death. Whatever killed him, a body couldn't end up like this in just three years."

Maybe not even in three hundred.

Would a shut-in Grand Mage whose hobby was magic research and whose specialty was staying home run his hideout on gas and electricity?

This enormous cavern, which could only be entered by breaking through its barriers, was filled with all kinds of magic. Everything, from the temperature to the humidity, was controlled perfectly.

And Siegfried's body showed none of the rot or stench of ordinary decay.

It's just… dried out. As if something sucked every bit of life from it.

I'd never seen a death this strange, even in Murim.

Which left me with more questions. How had he died in his own hideout? And how deeply was his death connected to my enemies?

"Michael Silbert. And The Prophet."

The two likeliest suspects.

Magic Johnson understood what I meant. "If I had to choose one of them, I'd pick the first without hesitation."

"Why?"

“Because we know there’s a connection between Michael and Siegfried. From everything we’ve seen, Michael Silbert must know Sky is unconscious. Otherwise, he’d never have joined forces with terrorists to pull off something this insane.”

It was a plausible theory. Siegfried had built Area A inside Ares Guild’s headquarters, and he could well have learned the truth about Cheon Taemin’s condition while doing it.

But…

“I’m asking because I don’t know, but was Siegfried close to Michael Silbert when he was alive?”

“That…”

“Then how likely is it that he told Michael a secret that big?”

Magic Johnson paused and let out a low groan.

“Unlikely. No, you might as well call it impossible. Very few people had any relationship with Siegfried, myself included. And there was only one person he ever said he truly respected.”

I had a feeling I knew the answer.

“Cheon Taemin.”

Magic Johnson nodded. “That’s right. Siegfried genuinely respected Sky. From what he told me, it was practically worship. He even spoke about Sky in an interview once.”

“Oh. I think I remember that.”

I had a vague memory of seeing the interview. There were online profiles full of information about well-known Hunters, Siegfried Bassmann among them. I’d heard the interview caused a stir at the time: it was unusual enough for him to speak to the press, let alone express such strong feelings about anyone.

“Perhaps… that’s why Lee Jungryong commissioned Siegfried to build Area A.”

Team Leader Choi spoke up suddenly, then continued slowly.

“Siegfried Bassmann was a master in that field, and he had very few personal relationships. On top of that, he deeply respected my maternal grandfather. He would have kept the secret.”

Magic Johnson gave a small nod.

“That’s true. Even I knew nothing about Area A, and I was one of the people closest to him. Hell, I never thought he’d accept a commission from anyone.”

“At least when it came to maintaining secrecy, Lee Jungryong’s judgment was accurate. But if the information wasn’t leaked, the question that remains is…”

“How did Michael Silbert find out?”

I muttered the question as I examined the body again, searching every inch for signs of torture. Even with every sense sharpened, I found nothing new.

If this wasn't simply a lizard shedding its tail, then there had to be a reason he needed to be killed.

I couldn't prove it yet, but Michael Silbert was still our likeliest suspect. Finding out what had happened here could be the first step toward bringing him down.

There's something. There has to be…

I kept searching the body, repeating those words to myself. At last, frustrated, I looked up and saw someone standing nearby.

Or rather, a monster shaped like a person.

"Why are you standing there trying to look cool? You've been quiet this whole time."

The Skeleton King stood with his arms crossed, deep in thought. He frowned.

"Silence, foolish human. This body was engaged in profound contemplation."

"What kind of bullshit were you contemplating now?"

"Can you not feel it?"

I stopped. "Feel what?"

"This space. The concentration of magical power is higher here than elsewhere."

If he'd said *mana*, I would have argued immediately. My Qi Sense was better than anyone else's here, and I hadn't noticed anything unusual.

But magical power was another matter. The Skeleton King was an S-rank monster. When it came to sensing magical power, even I couldn't match him.

"Large human. Did you not feel it?"

Magic Johnson scratched the back of his head.

"I did, though not as clearly as you. I just didn't think it was strange."

"You are infinitely more foolish than this body. Why?"

"This isn't just a house. It's also a laboratory equipped with everything Siegfried could want. You could rummage through a single storage room and find mountains of monster corpses and Magic Gems."

"…Huh?"

Oh. He had a point.

Just as filtering shit water wouldn't make it perfectly clear, the same was true of Magic Gems and monster corpses. No matter how thoroughly they were purified, some magical power would remain.

Siegfried's hideout was full of things that held magical power. No wonder the concentration was high.

"I see what you're thinking," Johnson went on, "but even if monsters are the reason there's so much magical power here, that doesn't tell us anything. If a monster killed Siegfried, there should at least be signs of a fight."

"…H-huh?"

I was an idiot for getting my hopes up.

The Skeleton King could only blink at Johnson's perfectly reasonable objection. I muttered, "Fucking moron."

"How dare this treacherous human insult whom!"

"Shut up before I pull your jawbone off. I'll let it slide since you actually tried thinking for once."

"…"

"Don't go confusing the investigation. My head's about to explode as it is."

The Demon Realm was far away. My fist was close.

The Skeleton King closed his mouth, looking thoroughly displeased. Team Leader Choi, who had continued examining the body, clicked his tongue.

"If this was an assassination, there should be at least a small wound. But there isn't one. The body is clean."

"Then…"

"Magic is the only explanation I can think of."

Yet even Magic Johnson, a Grand Mage himself, looked troubled.

"I specialize in offensive magic, but I've never seen or heard of anything like this. It's far more complex and sinister than the magic we use. Closer to that fellow's work, if anything."

"That fellow," who had been keeping his mouth firmly shut, frowned.

"This body merely places vengeful spirits into dead flesh. This body knows nothing of such wicked magic."

"…"

"…"

"…"

Isn't that already fucking wicked magic?

But since he said he did not know, what could I say? Besides, he was quite unlike an ordinary monster, so he had no reason to lie.

Damn it. It has to be him.

Michael Silbert.

That name alone kept circling through my mind.

Chapter 743

A space reserved for one person alone.

In the light that faintly illuminated the darkness, an eerie sound of flesh tearing echoed through the air.

Crack. Crack-crack.

Bones and muscles twisted. A tremendous force surged in time with the beating of a heart, bringing about a transformation.

What was weak grew strong.

What was strong grew stronger still.

The man's veins stood out across his body, and cold sweat had soaked him through. A thin line of blood slipped between his tightly pressed lips and ran down his chin.

Drip.

Drops of blood fell one by one.

Yet despite the agony wringing every part of his body, there was no trace of fear or pain in his gray eyes.

To some, it would have been worse than death. To him, it was familiar.

And the reward for enduring it was always sweet.

Just like now.

Hssssss.

The sickening cracks fell silent. At the same time, the energy that had been thrashing inside him rapidly settled. The veins bulging so grotesquely across his body slowly receded, and his muscles stopped convulsing.

Once again, the man received his "Reward."

Whoosh—boom!

In an instant, a tremendous wave of qi burst from him and swept in every direction. The light that had faintly illuminated the space vanished, and everything within some ten meters[3064] crumbled to dust.

It was power.

Overwhelming power.

Michael Silbert felt the change within himself and smiled.

Vrrrrr.

A faint vibration reached him from somewhere.

Michael knew exactly what it meant. He rose without hesitation and silently extended a hand. A hidden door opened, spilling light from the other side.

Step. Step.

[3064] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

His footsteps were strong and steady, as though the ordeal moments earlier had never happened. He crossed his study—vast was a better word for it—and stopped before a large mirror.

The full-length mirror glowed and faintly vibrated. Michael studied his reflection in its flawless surface, then laid a hand against the glass.

Tap.

In the next moment—

Flash!

A brief flare of light transformed the view in the mirror. Michael and his study vanished, replaced by an endless horizon, buildings moving slowly past, and a lone figure.

Dark skin, golden eyes, a silk top hat, and a monocle—the last two rarely seen these days.

Michael greeted the loyal retainer who had served him for years.

“You’ve been working hard, Huginn.”

Huginn tipped his hat to his superior.

“Not at all, Guild Master.”

That was greeting enough. As though by agreement, they went straight to business.

“The Swiss Federal Police recovered Siegfried Bassmann’s body an hour ago.”

“And those bastards?”

The question was brief. Huginn needed no clarification.

“They were questioned briefly as witnesses and released. If we push as hard as we can, we might drag them before the International Court of Justice, but I doubt we can take it any further.”

“I assume that isn’t just your own assessment. Who’s your source?”

“In Switzerland, Minister Berse.”

“Berse?”

Michael nodded calmly at the name of the Minister of the Interior, whose election as Switzerland’s president next year was considered all but certain.

“Then I’ve heard enough. We should let the matter end there.”

“I agree, Guild Master. Still, given what’s at stake, pursuing them to the end might be worth considering.”

“You want to throw them into a pit of filth, one way or another?”

“Shouldn’t we drag them in by the collar if we have to? The whole world will be watching as soon as this gets out. Siegfried Bassmann’s cause of death is unknown, and people will have questions. Then…”

“Conspiracy theories will spread. And those bastards will be their first targets.”

“Yes. Under the circumstances, wouldn’t that be effective?”

Michael shook his head without hesitation.

"Conspiracy theories are nonsense. Only fools obsessed with gossip and their own fantasies would suspect them."

Siegfried Bassmann had been a figure of tremendous stature, not just in Switzerland but around the world. Michael could easily use his death to spread theories about his enemies. It would just as easily backfire.

If he forcibly dragged his enemies into a pit of filth, some of that filth would splash onto him as well.

"Most people won't give those theories a second thought. Worse, some will start wondering whether everything that's happened around those bastards was staged. People who curse them today will take their side tomorrow."

As far as Michael knew, that was human nature. They were quick to condemn someone after being deceived by one tiny false aspect, then quickly changed their attitude once the whole truth came to light, gently embracing the person they had cursed.

As though nothing had happened.

As though the rest of the world had cursed him, but they never had.

Michael had no desire to see that happen. The plan's uncertain outcome was reason enough, but more importantly, its central figure was missing.

Jin Taekyung.

The name hovered on the tip of his tongue.

At most, Siegfried Bassmann's death might put pressure on Magic Johnson. Even that was unlikely. Unless Michael brought down Jin Taekyung—the man at the center of it all—he would only be wasting his strength.

"Leave the Swiss matter alone. There's nothing to gain from it."

Huginn answered the calm, firm order at once.

"Understood. I'll relay that to Minister Berse as well."

"Good. How are things with the media outlets?"

"Going well. We fed them firewood, and the flames took off. There is one matter I need to raise, though…"

"Money?"

"Yes. They've demanded much more than we expected."

"Greedy, aren't they? What they've already received should be more than enough."

"That's why I consider it fortunate. We only need to give them what they want."

Michael let out a quiet laugh. Huginn was right. Satisfy a person's greed at the right moment—better yet, give them more than they had imagined wanting—and they would never betray you.

"I'll give you access to some of my secret accounts. Take whatever you need."

"Should I take that to mean I can give them enough to astonish them?"

"Exactly. You've become quite the villain."

"I learned from a certain someone."

"There's an interesting saying among Easterners: 'When three people gather, they can make a tiger.'[3065] Keep the media under our control until this is over. Just as you have been."

"I'll keep that in mind."

Michael knew the power of the media. He knew, too, how shallow and frightening a crowd's judgment could be.

Part of him found it ridiculous that he had to go this far.

I was certain no one alive could stop me now, apart from Cheon Taemin.

Not the Ares Guild, once called the best in the world. Not Lee Jungryong, who had filled the void Cheon Taemin left behind. Not even the heroes of the Great Cataclysm, Magic Johnson among them.

None of them had been his match.

Then Jin Taekyung appeared.

How is that possible?

Michael could hardly believe it. He had been a young man from the slums with nothing but poverty to his name. Reaching his current position had taken years upon years of patience.

Jin Taekyung was different.

He had appeared out of nowhere and, in barely more than a year, amassed extraordinary achievements and Fame. The whole world had come to love him.

Just as it had loved someone from Michael's past, still vivid in his memory.

Sky.

One week ago, Michael had sensed a trace of Cheon Taemin in the young Asian man he met for the first time in the ruins.

He looked different. He felt different. But Michael's instincts had warned him.

He's dangerous.

He'll be the greatest obstacle in my way.

Those instincts had been right. Even with countless media outlets pouring out malicious stories, people had not stopped voicing their support for Jin Taekyung.

Those swept up in the terror of the attacks and the crowd mentality the media had cultivated were simply louder. Jin Taekyung still stood firm.

But if my guess is right… it's only a matter of time before he falls.

Michael thought to himself as he recalled Jin Taekyung's eyes, blazing with rage.

And someone who had stood beside him.

One step. Only one step remained between Michael and the summit he had longed to reach. He already held the flag that would proclaim his conquest.

[3065] The proverb refers to a false rumor becoming believable when several people repeat it.

"Huginn."

Huginn had waited in silence while his superior was lost in thought.

"Yes, Guild Master."

"There must be no mistakes or unexpected complications with this mission."

"Don't worry. I handled everything exactly as you ordered. Nothing was overlooked."

Michael smiled at the ready answer from the loyal retainer who had shared so many years—and so many secrets—with him.

"Good. That's all I need to hear."

"I won't disappoint you."

The man who had given the order and the man who had carried it out both knew what their actions would bring. They knew countless people would die or be injured.

To Michael, that was a minor detail.

It was an unavoidable sacrifice on the way to the goal he had long sought. If he could obtain what he wanted, then the sacrifice of those who would die somewhere in this vast world was an absurdly cheap price.

Crash!

The magically treated glass shattered at once. A moment ago, it had been a communications crystal ball. Now a wave swept its countless fragments away.

Whooosh.

Wind swept over Huginn as he stood at the stern, gazing at the rolling sea.

Three days at the latest. It'll probably begin before then.

The crystal ball's fragments were not the only things he had cast into the deep. Before long, the whole world would see the result.

The calculations were perfect. The mission was a success.

He felt no guilt. Only the satisfaction of having carried out his orders perfectly, and one small question he had yet to answer.

Will this be enough to bring Jin Taekyung down completely?

Huginn shook his head. The superior he served was always thorough, and the path he chose had always been the right one.

"We're heading back. Get ready."

At his brief command, the ship turned.

Behind it, growing slowly more distant, Tokyo's forest of buildings rose against the sky.

Chapter 744

A thought occurred to me.

I wished that everything tormenting me right now was merely a scene from some movie or novel. Something like that.

Then at least some evidence would pop up somewhere.

Of course, contrary to the hope I had secretly been holding on to, nothing of the sort happened.

Everyone, myself included, searched every inch of Siegfried Bassmann's hideout, but what popped out wasn't evidence concerning his death. It was a person.

More precisely, over a hundred Hunters from the Swiss Federal Police, who had followed us and arrived late.

"Everyone, please stop."

"We're taking control of the scene under legal procedure. Put down whatever you're holding immediately and…"

Well, what else could we do?

If they had abruptly pointed swords at us, I would have answered with my spear. But they were carrying out official duties, and instead of swords, they had thrust forward the invincible cheat code known as legal procedure.

Even unorthodox swordsmen who drew their weapons at the slightest provocation hesitated in front of government soldiers.

And as a twenty-first-century modern man with a logical mindset, my answer had been decided from the start.

"Are you going to put us in handcuffs too?"

"…Excuse me?"

"Yeah, that'd be a bit much. So what do we do now?"

With countless media outlets wishing me a long and healthy life while cursing me to hell, causing another incident would've been insane.

My companions and I cooperated so obediently that even the Swiss Hunters were surprised. After undergoing a thorough body search and brief questioning, we were released.

The high-ranking official who introduced himself as the lead investigator had just one thing to say.

"Additional investigations related to this case will be conducted, so we ask for your continued cooperation in the future."

That was all.

We hadn't given them anything to hold against us, but their matter-of-fact response still surprised me.

According to Team Leader Choi, Michael Silbert's influence reached the leaders of countries across the world. Switzerland, in particular, was where he sheltered his astronomical wealth from taxes.

I was sure that bastard would use Switzerland to pressure us somehow.

Team Leader Choi had a straightforward answer.

"They deliberately let us go. Since it was clear that neither the evidence nor the circumstances had anything to do with us, they must have judged that pursuing the matter any further would be difficult."

"That bastard Michael let us go on purpose? Just getting dragged into this case would already hurt us."

"The public is fickle. Right now, quite a few people are cursing us because they're being controlled by the media and mob psychology. But that's because The Prophet and terrorism provide a plausible justification at first glance."

"And if the reason doesn't hold up, people won't buy it?"

"People have acted on what they consider justified for thousands of years. If that justification falls apart, a good number of those condemning us will change sides."

"Oh."

Come to think of it, that was a pattern people displayed often—no, quite frequently.

You only had to look at the entertainment news on any online portal. The moment a celebrity got caught up in a scandal, netizens swarmed like bees to the honey the media had put out.

There were the genius prophets who claimed they had known it would happen ever since the celebrity's debut, and even twenty-first-century physiognomists insisting that face-reading was a science.

And around the time the winner of that world's greatest malicious-comment contest was crowned by upvotes, a new fact would emerge and turn the situation around, and the swarm would change its tune in an instant.

Why?

Simple.

They had no excuse to keep cursing them.

Siegfried Bassmann's mysterious death was that kind of case. Michael Silbert understood how people worked, and he knew exactly when to press on and when to stop.

"Michael is, in a word, a madman."

Magic Johnson broke the silence, his voice subdued.

"But the biggest reason we need to be wary of him is that this mad bastard is more meticulous and stronger than anyone."

Even the Skeleton King wore an uncharacteristically grave expression.

"I agree. When I first saw that bastard in Paris, I felt something so eerie that it was difficult to believe he was human."

Most madmen ended up in prison or a psychiatric hospital.

But when a madman like Michael had everything, the world had another name for him.

One of the powerful.

Of the people I'd met in the modern world, Lee Jungryong qualified. So did Go Jun, though he fell short of his Master in plenty of ways.

But that bastard…

He had already gone beyond that category.

You'd have to add those two together, then multiply the result, to get a madman like him.

Michael Silbert was a monster who'd given up being human.

Why? What could he possibly want to go this far?

I looked up. The sky was clear as hell, and the surrounding landscape had kept its northern European beauty. It couldn't have been more at odds with what was happening.

Fuck.

I muttered a quiet curse inwardly, then pulled a small pouch from inside my clothes and handed it to Magic Johnson.

"Here."

"This is… a subspace pocket."

"Don't open it yet. Take it with you and look through it properly. Team Leader Choi and I are hopeless when it comes to magic. We wouldn't know what we were looking at."

"Magic? Jin, what are you suddenly talking about?"

He looked bewildered. Then his eyes widened.

"Don't tell me…"

"Yeah. I swiped it earlier. I'm sure the deceased would understand."

"…"

"…"

"…"

All three stood there with their mouths open. Well, two people and one monster. I made a show of sighing.

"Not the reaction I was hoping for. Should I return it?"

Magic Johnson snatched the pocket.

"N-no, that's not what I meant. But how did you…?"

"The Hunters assigned to me were pretty lax with their body search."

Team Leader Choi blinked at me. “Lax?”

“Yeah.”

A blatant lie, of course.

A Grand Mage’s magical research materials were an immense treasure in their own right.

The Swiss Hunters had thoroughly searched the subspace pockets we carried, worried that even one of the materials might be smuggled out.

They hadn’t searched my Inventory.

More precisely, they couldn’t have.

As soon as I gave up looking for evidence on the body, I’d started scooping up materials. Anything that looked even remotely promising. Whatever I could lay my hands on.

The result of that theft was now in Magic Johnson’s hands.

“We didn’t notice a thing,” he said. “When did you manage all this?”

“I told you. They weren’t watching closely, so I slipped it out.”

“You secretly slipped it out?”

He opened the pocket and looked inside.

“…Jin. You didn’t steal the entire laboratory, did you?”

“…”

“…Jin?”

Well. I had picked up this and that, so I had brought quite a lot.

Everyone had been distracted, though, and there were mountains of documents left behind. It probably wasn’t that obvious.

Probably.

“Anyway, is it enough to work with?”

“Enough? Are you serious? There’s more than enough.”

“Then please investigate it based on those materials for the time being.”

“But with everything happening, I can’t focus entirely on—no. I’ll do my best. If I find even the smallest clue in here, Michael won’t be able to carry on like this.”

I nodded.

“Please do.”

The distribution of magical power had intensified again, and the damage was mounting. Magic Johnson would be a tremendous help with the aftermath, but we needed to deal with the root of the problem first.

“We’ll gather information from other angles,” Team Leader Choi said. “If we can locate one person, we may be able to prevent the worst.”

Magic Johnson answered with something like a sigh.

“The Prophet.”

"Yes. If either of the two heads is removed, things should improve considerably."

"If we could eliminate The Prophet, all the better. We have Jin. Find out where the man is, and he's dead. The problem is…"

"I know. Even the Pentagon hasn't located him yet. But we have to try."

Michael Silbert and The Prophet.

The Prophet and Michael Silbert.

The two madmen moved as though they were one, but The Prophet was by far the easier one for me to eliminate.

Kill the master of the world's greatest Guild, and I'd be a fucking bastard on par with Demon King Asmodeus. Bring back the head of a fanatical terrorist, and the whole world would cheer.

"We'll find him," I said, calm despite the anger in my voice. "Even if we have to turn over the entire desert."

The civilization humanity had built was magnificent.

The sight of people cheering after discovering fire for the first time in the distant past could no longer be found anywhere.

Those wandering groups had become farming societies. Factories rose where fields and rice paddies had once stood, and humanity forged the modern world from steel and blood.

Humanity, once the weakest of all, had thus become the master of this blue planet.

They flew across the sky faster than light, ventured into space, and used weapons born of that progress to kill one another.

Humanity was the ruler of this land, its people, and an explorer forever moving forward.

But even humanity could not do everything.

Some unknown realms remained beyond its reach after hundreds of millions of years, impossible to explore even with magic.

One was the infinite expanse of space. The other lay deep beneath the sea, where light could not reach.

The deep sea.

Even adventurers who had discovered the five oceans and six continents and reached into the domain of outer space had never set foot there. It was still filled with countless speculations and secrets.

No—perhaps it was a secret that should never have been pried into.

Shhrrk.

Something enormous moved. Hundreds of deep-sea fish had mistaken it for part of the terrain and strayed close. They could not withstand the power within it and were torn in half.

Crunch.

The lightless depths swallowed their red blood.

Hssss.

A faint light spread beyond the darkness.

Each time the scales covering something enormous, several meters[3066] in radius, shifted, the surrounding space alternately brightened and darkened.

At last, the center of the glow shone clearly.

It was no luminous organ like those found on some deep-sea fish. The power it held was beyond comparison.

It was an eye.

The eye of a creature so enormous that it was difficult to believe.

A monster everyone thought had vanished long ago had awakened after an unfathomable span of time.

[3066] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

Chapter 745

The desert night was bitterly cold.

The scorching sun and heat haze were gone. In their place remained subzero temperatures and an unusually large moon.

A temperature swing of sixty degrees[3067] in a single day.

But even the bitter cold could not stop the figure climbing a crescent-shaped dune.

Sssrrk.

Despite the steep slope, the figure moved as though gliding across the sand. The hem of a thin silk robe brushed the grains, then came to a stop.

"This is the place."

The moment that flat voice sounded, the empty air rippled.

Ffft.

With a faint sound, a dozen or so figures descended onto the dune. Their faces hidden behind black masks and turbans, they each dropped respectfully to one knee and whispered,

"Inshallah.[3068] We pay our respects to the great Prophet who has returned to this land."

Standing alone before them, the Prophet's robe fluttered lightly.

"Inshallah.[3069] I wondered when you would reveal yourselves."

Those words made it clear that the Prophet had seen through everything from the beginning. The dozen pairs of eyes visible above the masks trembled.

"Prophet…"

"I know. You followed me because you care for me, even though it meant defying my orders."

"If you would punish us for our disobedience, we would gladly pay for it with our lives. But we, the Hasasin, will never leave your side, no matter the circumstances."

The Hasasin. Or the Assassins.

Their stronghold had fallen to their enemies around the thirteenth century. For centuries afterward, the ancient order of assassins had survived as little more than a religious sect, until the Great Cataclysm brought it back to life.

Its members would not be dissuaded.

"The Western heretics are cunning, and they wield great power. If they were to discover you…"

"Al-Nizar. Loyal beyond any other, yet foolish and full of worry."

[3067] A temperature change of 60 degrees Celsius is equivalent to a change of 108 degrees Fahrenheit.

[3068] *Inshallah* is Arabic for "God willing."

[3069] *Inshallah* is Arabic for "God willing."

"…!"

"Look at me."

The leader of the Hasasin flinched and cautiously raised his head.

His great Prophet gazed down at him, silhouetted against a sky strewn with stars. Within the strangely dark folds of the robe, a pair of eyes shone with a mysterious light.

"Do you still not understand?"

The Prophet raised both arms toward the sky.

Vwoooom.

An immense force swelled beneath the robe, pushing its folds outward. The wind died. The air vibrated.

The Hasasin swallowed without realizing it. Their eyes followed the Prophet's hands, and in the next moment—

Shhhhhhhk.

They saw it: a transparent membrane that began in the sky and curved around them, enclosing an area several hundred meters[3070] in radius.

It was both a protective barrier that no product of science—not even Magic—could detect and a screen that concealed them from their enemies' eyes.

"As long as I protect you, they will not find so much as our shadows."

"…!"

"…!"

Even the Hasasin, who had endured extreme training, could not hide their surging emotions at that moment.

Their Prophet possessed such astonishing power. And the Prophet had called lowly servants like them *us*.

"Inshallah[3071]…!"

"Prophet!"

Their cries of joy and emotion echoed through the quiet desert.

But the Prophet had another miracle to show them.

Sssrrk.

The long, loose sleeve of the robe fluttered. The crescent-shaped dune beneath their feet shook.

No—it split apart.

Crk-crk-crk!

It was a wondrous sight.

[3070] Several hundred meters is roughly 1,000–3,000 ft.

[3071] *Inshallah* is Arabic for "God willing."

In the distant past, Moses had parted the Red Sea and led the Hebrews across it. Now, more than a thousand years later, a new Prophet had divided part of a vast sea of sand in two.

What lay hidden beneath those countless grains glittered in the moonlight like a gift from God.

“My God…”

“Prophet, what are those?”

Instead of answering, the Prophet silently extended a hand.

Clank. Clank. Clank!

Locks burst apart under an invisible force. The leader of the Hasasin stared wide-eyed at the contents of the dozens of iron chests.

“T-this is…”

Even the darkness could not hide their brilliance.

Gold and silver bars in quantities he had never seen, and weapons imbued with various kinds of Magic, dazzled him. But something else shocked him most of all.

“Magic Gems…!”

The cry that escaped him like a groan was the truth.

Magic Gems.

Hundreds of them, unmistakably high-grade to top-grade. Some were exceptionally large and radiated immense power.

Fwoooosh.

Even he, a leader of the Hasasin who had reached the realm of an S-rank Hunter, could not easily approach that powerful energy.

“Hk.”

He drew a sharp breath before he could stop himself. The Prophet’s familiar, toneless voice reached him.

“S-rank Magic Gems. Their original power remains intact.”

“P-Prophet…”

“Stand back. That power is beyond you.”

With that quiet warning, the unrefined S-rank Magic Gems floated into the air. They moved like living things and disappeared into the Prophet’s robe.

Ten of them.

The leader of the Hasasin watched, his gaze trembling.

How did the Prophet get hold of those…?

He already knew the Prophet’s abilities defied common sense.

But from the Great Cataclysm until now, only a little over a hundred S-rank monsters had officially appeared in human history.

On extremely rare occasions, a tiny number of A-rank monsters had possessed S-rank Magic Gems. But those instances were exactly what they were—exceptional

cases. Even in the Middle East, where countless Gates existed, S-rank Magic Gems had appeared only once or twice.

Yet here were ten of them, their original magical power intact.

That's an incredible amount. It's impossible to believe.

His faith in the Prophet was boundless, but this time he could not help wanting to ask.

He turned his head—and met the faintly glowing eyes within the robe.

"Tell me. Who do you think stands before you?"

"…!"

The gaze seemed to see through him. Shock struck the leader of the Hasasin like lightning, and he dropped to his knees.

How dare someone like him question the Prophet's actions?

It was something that could not happen—and must never happen.

"Great Prophet, please forgive this sinful servant!"

The air froze.

The other Hasasin touched their weapons and waited for the Prophet to speak. If the order came, they were ready to kill their own leader without a moment's hesitation.

The Prophet spoke God's word and led them all.

Since the death of the Prophet Muhammad, the Islamic world had spent more than a thousand years feuding and fighting. Blood had stained the desert sands.

Over time, a tiny few had gained immense wealth and power. But in the great cities built on oil, the word of Allah had given way to the capitalism of apostates.

It was time to bring Allah's children, who had turned their blades on one another, back to a single root—and to save their fellow believers persecuted even in the Western world.

In the name of the great God.

In the name of the Prophet who had come to them decades ago in God's stead.

And just as an invisible blade slowly cut through the silence, one tightly closed mouth finally opened.

"Al-Nizar."

The voice revealed neither age nor even gender.

The leader of the Hasasin swallowed. Cold sweat had soaked him from head to toe.

"Prophet."

"One last piece of advice, my son of God. You are still immature—and that is precisely why I care for you all the more."

"…!"

"Inshallah.[3072] All of this is the result of the long patience and providence God has granted me. You must never doubt it. Do you understand?"

"I'll remember. I'll remember."

Drip.

Cold sweat and tears fell together onto the sand.

The Prophet gazed kindly at the leader as he trembled with relief and emotion, then continued.

"The time has come again. Tell your brothers who have been preparing."

Everyone's eyes widened.

Nearly ten days had passed since the day they called "Allah's Judgment." All who followed the Prophet had been waiting impatiently for the next day of judgment.

"Prophet. Do you mean…?"

"God wills it. Bring down His hammer upon the apostates eating away at us from within and the Western heretics."

The eyes visible above the masks gleamed with fanaticism and exultation.

The Prophet looked up at the star-strewn sky and murmured,

"There is not much time left until the end."

Some wanted catastrophe. Some struggled to prevent it. Still others wanted something beyond it.

Even now, each was racing toward a different goal.

Sugihara Gyoiku was a laborer who had worked in cargo shipping for a long time.

He was a lifelong Tokyo native and, at the same time, a seasoned laborer who had entered the maritime transport industry when he was young.

People sometimes looked down on him for doing manual labor, but he did not care much. Not everyone could be a Hunter, lawyer, or doctor, and the world needed people like him, too.

Lately, though, he had been in a foul mood.

How could he not be?

Chikushō.[3073] Damn monsters.

Just ten days earlier, a Monster Wave in Tokyo had killed and injured many people.

Tokyo Tower, which he had secretly been proud of as a Tokyo native, had collapsed horribly. The chicken restaurant he had frequented for thirty years had also vanished in the aftermath.

[3072] *Inshallah* is Arabic for "God willing."

[3073] *Chikushō* is a Japanese exclamation meaning "damn it."

I didn't like that the owner was a Chosenjin,[3074] *but the chicken was incredible.*

Gyoiku was sad that he could no longer stop in for Korean-style chicken and beer after work. Still, he went to work today as usual.

"Gyoiku-san.[3075] You're here?"

"Yo."

He exchanged brief greetings with the other dockworkers and headed straight to the work site. Cargo ships already crowded Tokyo Bay.

"Where should we start?"

"We've already started. Come on."

As Gyoiku loaded cargo onto a ship, he chatted with his coworkers. Tokyo's magical-power levels had been rising particularly fast lately. The prime minister, scion of a prominent political family, had said something insane again.

Then someone mentioned a tsunami.

"A tsunami?"

"Yeah. Apparently it's getting closer to Tokyo. They say it's huge."

"Hmm."

"Don't worry. The government said it would die down soon."

"Guess it will."

Gyoiku felt a little uneasy, but only a little. Even if there was a tsunami, it would never make it all the way to Tokyo. Tokyo Bay was sheltered by the land around it, and its magical defense systems were firmly in place.

Maybe I'll look for a new Korean chicken place after work.

Gyoiku straightened his back, thinking about something pointless—and froze like a statue.

"Huh?"

What is that?

The question flashed through his mind. A moment later, he remembered what he had just heard.

The tsunami.

Gyoiku stared blankly, mouth open, toward the sea beyond the harbor.

A wave larger than any he had ever seen was racing toward him. It rose so high it looked ready to blot out the sun.

Gooooooong.

Along with the cry of some unknown thing—a sound that froze him merely by hearing it.

[3074] *Chosenjin* is a Japanese ethnic slur for Koreans.

[3075] *-san* is a Japanese honorific suffix used as a polite form of address.

Chapter 746

Returning to everyday life usually means things have settled down.

But immediately after the mysterious death of Siegfried Bassmann, we returned to our respective positions only to face a frantic stretch of time.

“The magical-power reading at the C-rank Gate in Sokcho, Gangwon Province, is rising rapidly. It’s at Stage Two… entering Stage Three! We have a mutation Gate!”

“How many people can we deploy?”

“Four teams are on standby at the Gangwon Province branch. The Teleport Magic Formation linked to Sokcho City Hall can get them to the site within five minutes.”

“Send them now. This could turn into a monster wave. Make rescuing survivors and containing the situation your top priorities.”

The situation after our return was about as bad as it could get.

Until a few years ago, mutation Gates had appeared no more than once a month. Now we were seeing three or four a day—and that was just in Korea.

While stock prices rose and fell, magical-power readings climbed every single day.

Broadcasters cut back on entertainment shows. On newly launched disaster-news channels, experts from every field argued fiercely.

“Many people overlook the fact that magical-power readings have risen steadily every year. Compared to the period immediately after the Great Cataclysm, today’s readings are actually quite low. Once this situation is resolved, things will settle down quickly, so the public needn’t worry—”

“Settle down quickly? What kind of nonsense is that? And how can you compare today with the period right after the Great Cataclysm? After we killed the Demon King on the ‘Day of Victory,‘ did humanity put down its weapons and dance Ganggangsullae together?[3076] Back then, you could go to Han River Park and find Lizardmen. It took nearly a year just to finish off the monster armies that were still out there. Have you forgotten?”

“I live in Ilsan, and I never saw any Lizardmen in Han River Park. I’m right.”

“What a fucking idiot…”

“Now, now. You’re a year younger than me. No need to swear.”

“A year younger, my ass, you fucking bastard. My parents registered my birth late. Happy?”

“Mr. Host, are you going to let him talk to me like that?”

The sight of white-haired academic authorities turning red in the face on TV and fighting over whose argument would win was no longer particularly surprising.

While they grabbed each other by the collars, the next channel was reporting breaking news of a mutation Gate or monster wave somewhere in the world.

[3076] Ganggangsullae is a traditional Korean circle dance and folk song.

And at those horrific scenes, I fought as hard as I could.

Shhk!

White Flame's spearhead sliced cleanly through hide and bone harder than armor.

The enormous monster—I had no idea how many I'd killed by then—stopped dead in its tracks. Then it slowly turned around and split in two from top to bottom.

Shff. Thud!

As its three-meter[3077] body fell in two equal halves, I met the eyes of a man sprawled a few steps away.

He had escaped death by a hair. In his hand was a plastic protest sign painted with red letters.

ARREST INTERNATIONAL CRIMINAL JIN TAEKYUNG!!!

Hmm.

I wondered how I was supposed to react, then gave him a rueful smile.

Even if he hated me, three exclamation marks seemed a bit much.

"Are you okay?"

"…Ah."

"You look all right apart from a few scratches, but stay seated just in case. It's over now. The rescue team will be here soon."

I left the man moving his lips without a word and turned away.

In barely thirty minutes, the street had been devastated. Monster carcasses lay among human bodies.

I sharpened my senses and searched the area, but felt no other signs of life.

The damage never should have been this bad.

It was tragic enough that a monster wave had struck this peaceful little city.

And that the hundreds of protesters gathered to condemn me had chosen this street for their rally.

Splash. Splash.

I crossed the street through puddles of mingled red and blue blood.

The hyenas had already caught the scent. They rushed me with cameras and microphones.

"What do you think of this monster wave?"

"You arrived before anyone else and stopped the monster wave! First, as a fellow human being, I'd like to express my deepest gratitude—"

"These people were here to condemn you. Could someone who supports you have caused this monster wave deliberately—"

"Why hasn't Mr. Sky appeared yet? What connection do you have to the recent death of Siegfried Bassmann?"

[3077] Three meters is about 9.8 ft.

“Jin, give us a statement!”

It felt as though filth were raining down on me from every direction.

A few defended me, but far more reporters were desperate for sensational headlines.

And I suspected many of them were being paid handsomely to ask those questions.

By someone like…

Odin Guild.

I’d already suspected as much. I hadn’t been particularly surprised when Team Leader Choi first told me.

Turn the media against us, and public opinion would follow.

Dragging me and Ares Guild through the mud so openly, when we had overwhelming public support, wasn’t something just anyone could attempt.

Michael Silbert had both the power and the justification to try.

The problem was that, in the media at least, it was working far better than I’d imagined.

“The Prophet still hasn’t shown himself. What would you say to him, knowing he’s watching you from somewhere?”

“Statistics show that Ares Guild handles an average of 3.6 incidents a day, while Odin Guild handles 6.5. Any comment?”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung! Mr. Jin Taekyung!”

“Hey, you! What kind of question is that? You call yourselves reporters?”

“Everyone, step back. Now!”

It was chaos.

Reporters pushed forward for more stories and more payoffs. Police officers and Hunters struggled to hold them back.

I slipped between them, my stomach churning, while a voice seemed to echo inside my head.

You humans… really are a shitshow.

I never thought I’d hear that from a monster.

But I had no answer.

Maybe seeing that sign had taken the fight out of me.

“Shut up. You’re loud.”

I hadn’t used much internal energy, but I was mentally exhausted. After giving the Skeleton King a curt reply inside my Inventory, I pulled out the Magic Scroll I’d brought and tore it.

Riiip. Fwoosh!

The familiar sensation of Teleport Magic swept through me.

The scenery changed in an instant. As my vision cleared, I saw a familiar face.

"You're back early. I only just heard you were on your way."

Exhaustion weighed on Song Song's voice, and she had dark circles under her eyes that hadn't been there before. She promptly held out a handkerchief.

"Wipe your face. You've got blood on it."

I looked from the handkerchief to her and smacked my lips.

"Just curious. Are you saving your Clean Magic to make soup with?"

"Do you think Magic works by putting coins into it? You can chug potions to replenish mana, but you can't replenish mental energy that's already been spent. I'm already not getting enough sleep these days, so shut up and use the handkerchief."

I knew who was chiefly responsible for her lack of sleep, so I couldn't argue.

I wiped off the blood and handed it back. Song Song took the dirty handkerchief and quietly cast a spell.

"Clean."

"…?"

Whoosh.

Dust and blood vanished, leaving the handkerchief spotless.

I stared at her. She blinked innocently.

"What? It's designer."

At that shameless answer—and the realization that she'd set me up for it—I couldn't help snorting.

"Ha."

"There. You're smiling. You looked miserable on TV."

"You were watching?"

"I saw it live. Heard those fucking reporters talking bullshit, too."

"…Well, I guess I have to take it. When you get down to it, I bear some responsibility for this mess."

Song Song frowned.

"Are you going to start talking bullshit too?"

"…"

"I thought you were getting back to normal. What's with you? If you want to blame yourself that badly, kill those bastards first. Then you can beat yourself up all you like."

That was exactly what I wanted to do.

But it wasn't that easy. Three days had passed since our trip to Switzerland, and little had changed.

Magic Johnson's investigation had produced no results. Neither magic nor satellite surveillance could find a trace of The Prophet. And Michael Silbert's Odin Guild kept rising higher by the day.

“Don’t blame yourself so much, and don’t worry so much. You’re not the only one working hard. Uncle Kkeokjeong was raising hell yesterday, saying he’d go straight to Paris and cut Michael’s head off.”

“That… It’s reassuring to have an entire army on our side, but if he did that, Uncle Kkeokjeong would be the one losing his head.”

“Yeah. That’s exactly what I told him.”

“You told him that?”

“Of course. It’s true. He was a bit dejected, but he came around pretty quickly.”

Well, I was grateful for that much.

Song Song and I talked as we walked. By the time she’d finished telling me about my mother and Hayeon, who were staying at the mansion under tight security, we had reached Team Leader Choi’s office.

“You’re here.”

He looked even more exhausted than Song Song. His usually immaculate office was a mess, and empty coffee cups covered the desk.

“Thank you for making the long trip. But…”

Team Leader Choi looked back and forth between Song Song and me, then lowered his voice.

“Where’s the other one?”

“Don’t worry. He came with me.”

I’m here.

Had I kept him shut away too long? He sounded furious.

I took the Skeleton King out of my Inventory, pretending to rummage through the subspace pouch at my waist as I recited the command.

Inventory open. Summon.

A sturdy young white man popped into view. Song Song muttered, “Wow. Easy birth.”

“Shut your mouth, beautiful but ill-mannered human female. How dare you compare this body to such a thing…”

“Thanks. I feel so much better now.”

“Damn it.”

The Skeleton King’s face was full of displeasure as he muttered a curse, but there was nothing we could do about it.

Even if his identity is partly out in the open, we need to keep him hidden as much as we can.

We’d given him a new past and identity, but nothing in this world was perfect. Even the Pentagon, supposedly the most secure place on earth, had been breached the same way.

Given the circumstances, we had no choice but to limit his exposure as much as possible.

But Team Leader Choi’s next words made me realize we would have to play the Skeleton King card.

“Three minutes ago, Tokyo Bay collapsed.”

Chapter 747

Beneath a sky shrouded in dark clouds, Sugihara Gyoiku stared blankly ahead.

What the hell just happened?

He was an ordinary civilian. His mind could not make sense of what had happened to him.

His arms and legs shook beyond his control. His stomach, full of salty seawater, could not bear the rescue helicopter's rough movements.

No—perhaps what Gyoiku truly could not endure was the horrifying reality that had suddenly come crashing down on him.

"Ugh—bwaaaargh!"

Vomit sprayed everywhere.

Some of it hit the other people in the rescue net with him, but no one complained. No one even seemed to notice.

They only stared at the scene below with vacant eyes.

Craaaack!

Things broke, collapsed, and were swept away.

A wave dozens of meters[3078] high. Perhaps even hundreds of meters.[3079]

Even as they watched it happen, they could scarcely believe the disaster swallowing everything in its path.

The port of Tokyo Bay, where hundreds of ships came and went every day, had vanished without a trace. Cargo ships weighing tens of thousands of metric tons[3080] apiece broke apart like Styrofoam and rode the waves into a nearby industrial complex.

Rumble—BOOM!

Flames surged upward with a deafening roar, swallowing people's screams.

Alarms wailed without pause. Far below, cars and crowds that looked as small as swarms of ants scattered in every direction.

Fleeing the disaster.

Unable to accept the fate that had befallen them.

And behind those struggling desperately to survive, an enormous shadow fell across the ground.

Whooooooosh!

"Ah… Ahhh…"

The survivors watching from above let out hollow moans.

[3078] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–300 ft.

[3079] Hundreds of meters is roughly 100–900 m, or about 330–3,000 ft.

[3080] Tens of thousands of metric tons is roughly 20,000–90,000 metric tons, or about 22,000–99,000 US short tons.

The land they had painstakingly rebuilt through decades of sweat and blood after the Great Cataclysm was collapsing. A magnificent civilization was falling apart.

The white foam that had always scattered against the breakwaters and the blue seawater had both turned red.

Nothing could stop that enormous wave as it smashed through and swept away everything in its path.

No. Even if the wave subsided, it would make no difference.

This was not merely a natural disaster.

Something worse lurked beneath the deep waters that had swallowed the port and industrial complex.

The survivors who had miraculously lived through it knew the truth. That was why, upon spotting dozens of fighter jets flying toward them from the opposite direction, they could only scream as though coughing up blood.

“N-No!”

“Don’t come!”

But their desperate cries reached no one.

Not the squadron of fighter jets streaking across the sky with sonic booms. Not the elite Japanese Hunters aboard them, sent to deal with the disaster.

And not the deep-sea monster awakened from its long sleep.

Gooooooong.

A low, immense call raised the waves just as they had begun to subside.

The strengthening wind whipped into a storm. Thunder rumbled among the countless dark clouds that now covered the sky.

Rumble, rumble…

Every living thing nearby froze like a statue and stared blankly upward.

It was fear engraved deep in their bones, an instinct they felt simply because they were alive.

Power.

The power of nature—and yet something beyond nature.

“What the hell is that…?”

The pilot was about to order the waiting Hunters to descend when the words escaped him in a groan.

At that moment—

Fwoosh!

Hundreds—thousands—of bolts of lightning plunged from the sky, turning the whole world white.

The Japanese Ministry of Defense's operations control room, hastily called into session, was silent.

Suffocating silence. Throats working soundlessly. Unfocused eyes.

Dozens of high-ranking officials and generals were present, but no one spoke. They could only stare at the holographic screen with vacant eyes.

What… What just happened?

The same thought occupied every mind.

The flash had filled the screen with light so fierce that they had closed their eyes without realizing it. When they opened them again, all they saw were dozens of aircraft falling toward the ground—and the waves swallowing them.

"Th-They've all been wiped out."

Someone's thoughtless report broke the silence. It confirmed the truth none of them wanted to face.

Everything was gone. No—everyone was dead.

The hundreds, thousands of lightning bolts had turned everything within their range to ash.

The rescue helicopters carrying the miraculous survivors. The Air Self-Defense Force's prized fighter squadron. The hundreds of Hunters mobilized for the emergency.

All gone.

But it was not only the tsunami—already engulfing ten cities and threatening the capital—that had plunged the control room into deathly silence.

The monster.

They had seen a monster that had vanished decades ago, one they had believed would never return.

"…Susanoo."

The nickname came from its supposed command of the sea and storms.

The general who muttered it hurriedly shut his mouth when he felt the Defense Minister's glare.

"Th-That was…"

"Shut your trap, Yoshimura."

The Japanese Defense Minister cut off the general's attempted excuse and looked around.

Half the people who should have been devising a response were still floundering in shock. The rest waited for him to speak again.

Like baby birds waiting to be fed.

Or people looking for the one scapegoat willing to take responsibility in their place.

Grind.

The elderly Defense Minister clenched his teeth.

For all the generals and officials in this room, he could not find a single suitable person.

The foolish, cowardly Prime Minister had retreated to a bunker long ago. The few capable, responsible commanders lacked the powerful backers needed to get into the Ministry of Defense's control room.

That left only one person to shoulder the burden.

Incompetent bastards!

He cursed them inwardly, forgetting that he owed his own rise to an ancestor who had been a daimyo.[3081] But he was not so foolish that he could deny the reality before him.

"Stop that thing with everything we have! Self-Defense Forces, Hunters—I don't care. Use every means at our disposal!"

"Y-Yes, sir!"

"And…"

Bang!

The Defense Minister slammed his wrinkled hand on the table, then squeezed his eyes shut. He could not bring himself to finish.

Do we really… do we really have to go this far?

The hesitation lasted only a moment.

The situation had already spiraled out of control. If anyone could keep it from becoming an even greater disaster, it was *that man*.

"Ask the world for help. And that man in particular—we must bring him here, no matter what diplomatic price we have to pay."

"What?"

"If it's him…"

His lips trembled like a child faced with a plate of broccoli.

Then, facing the people staring back at him with no idea what he meant, the Defense Minister shouted until it seemed as though he were coughing up blood.

"That man! I said call that Chōsenjin![3082] Jin Taekyuuung!"

His pride as a subject of the Great Japanese Empire rebelled at the thought, but he had no choice.

That monster—Leviathan—was a demon sent down from heaven.

We can't let that nightmare happen again!

Before long, news reports playing on holographic televisions throughout the control room confirmed that he had been right to choose Jin Taekyung.

[3081] A daimyo was a Japanese feudal lord who governed a domain.

[3082] A derogatory Japanese term for a Korean.

> —The world has once again been engulfed in flames. In a video, the figure known as “The Prophet,” who carried out an unprecedented series of terrorist attacks ten days ago, has announced a second series of attacks…

> —Breaking news. A Monster Wave has occurred in Manhattan, United States. The United States and countries around the world are entering a state of emergency…

> —Entry and exit bans are now in effect for countries experiencing Monster Waves. As a result, part of the emergency mobilization of Hunters to assist Tokyo has fallen through. Among nearby Asian countries, Korea is believed to be the only one able to provide support…

“Japan’s Ministry of Defense has officially requested emergency assistance through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.”

The news President Baek Hanseong passed on to us was the starting gun. Everything had begun.

“Ares Guild and Peace Guild are heading out as the advance team. Five teams are already standing by, all volunteers of B-rank or higher.”

Team Leader Choi had acted faster than anyone.

The moment he first heard what had happened in Tokyo, he had already issued the mobilization order. President Baek Hanseong had prepared the Air Force so that we could reach our destination as quickly and safely as possible.

“What about a Teleport Magic Formation?” I asked as I gathered the equipment we needed.

Team Leader Choi shook his head.

“We could try it, but the probability of failure is far too high right now. The magical-power distribution around Tokyo rose sharply because of the Monster Wave ten days ago, and it’s already measuring more than three times the previous level.”

“Damn it. Reminds me of China.”

“Yes. It’s the same situation.”

Mana and magical power were opposed to each other.

Attempt spatial travel while magical-power levels were climbing this fast and fluctuating this wildly, and even a body made of solid iron could come apart like a thousand-piece puzzle.

“Then how long will it take?”

“Allowing for the worsening weather nearby, about thirty minutes.”

“Thirty minutes…”

Of course, we would not be landing safely on a wide airport runway.

There was at least a ninety-percent chance that Tokyo International Airport, once the pride of Japan, had already been blown to absolute shit.

And the other ten percent is the chance it’ll be blown to shit before we get there.

I took a deep breath.

The footage Japan’s Ministry of Defense had sent us replayed in my mind.

The Maritime Self-Defense Force swept away by a gigantic triangular wave. Land disappearing beneath the water.

It had broken through the extensive defensive Magic along Japan’s coastline as though it were nothing, swallowed tens of thousands of people, and reduced what little hope remained to ash beneath countless bolts of lightning.

As though proving the power attributed to it in myths passed down from time immemorial.

Leviathan.

The devil of the sea that had ruled the waters during the Great Cataclysm.

One of the most powerful S-rank monsters under the Demon King Asmodeus. A calamity that had vanished when Asmodeus died.

Some said Leviathan had died with the Demon King. Others insisted it had survived and was merely biding its time. With no evidence either way, the years had passed.

And today, more than thirty years later, the nightmare called Leviathan had returned.

Was its appearance a coincidence, or…

Had someone intended it?

Muttering the unresolved question inwardly, I finished my preparations and began walking toward the Hunters and aircraft waiting for me.

The wind blowing from far away seemed to carry a faint smell of blood.

Chapter 748

"Jin Taekyung has accepted Japan's request for assistance."

Michael Silbert listened to Huginn's report and answered calmly.

"And?"

"Ares Guild and Peace Guild have assembled five teams of handpicked Hunters, and the Korean government has mobilized the Air Force to take them to Tokyo. I've prepared the Hunters' profiles, just in case."

Huginn handed him a tablet containing detailed information on every Hunter in the relief force. Michael glanced at it, and a faint smile crossed his lips.

"Well done. Any assistance from outside Korea?"

"None at present. China would be a great help if it joined in, but it lost its core forces in the war against the Arch Lich, and its relations with Japan are poor. It won't answer the request."

China had already suffered enormous losses fighting the Arch Lich and in the terrorist attack on Beijing ten days earlier.

Even with its vast number of Hunters, taking on a top-tier monster capable of causing a disaster by itself would be a heavy burden. All the more so when the request came from Japan, a country with which China had appalling diplomatic relations.

"There's no need to worry about China. Even if the old Chairman wants to help Jin Taekyung, circumstances at home won't allow it."

Huginn realized there was something he had not yet been told.

"Are you planning to strike China again?"

"Someone might get the wrong idea if they heard you say that. A terrorist attack is an unfortunate event no one can predict before it happens. Don't you agree?"

Michael held his gaze. Huginn lowered his head.

"My apologies. I misspoke."

"Don't worry about it. Everyone makes mistakes."

"…"

"And this is only my personal opinion, but I suspect Shanghai may be the next target."

His tone was casual, but Huginn could smell the thick blood embedded in those words.

Shanghai was China's most populous metropolis. After Beijing, which had been struck ten days ago, another staggering loss of life was all but certain.

China is paying dearly for siding with Jin Taekyung.

And China was hardly alone.

Most people saw the series of attacks as indiscriminate terrorism. But the countries and Guilds that had shown Jin Taekyung a friendly face were being punished.

And it'll end one of two ways.

Huginn muttered inwardly as he looked at his superior.

There stood a conqueror with greater ambitions than anyone else in the world, pressing toward his grand objective.

So why did Huginn feel this way?

I have a bad feeling about this.

The situation was perfect. Leviathan was a monster as powerful as the Arch Lich. And unlike the battle against the Arch Lich, in which no fewer than six S-rank Hunters had taken part, Jin Taekyung could expect no outside help this time beyond the forces already at his disposal, including Japan's.

But…

If Jin Taekyung manages to overcome even this…

The thought came to him ominously.

What if, just this once, his superior had made the wrong choice? What if this trap became the sturdy rope that pulled Jin Taekyung out of the mire?

A vibration soon buried Huginn's doubts.

Rrrrrumble.

"Entry into the operation area complete. Preparing to descend in ten seconds."

The pilot's report came through the speakers as the aircraft shook. Then Huginn heard his superior's quiet voice.

"It's begun."

Michael, now clad in dazzling silver armor, was looking out the window.

A city engulfed in the cries of monsters and towering flames. The battlefield where the name Michael Silbert would once again be etched into the minds of the world.

"Prepare yourself, Huginn."

He pressed a crown-engraved helmet onto his head. Looking like a god of old, he spoke to his crow once more.

"Prepare to become the best—beyond anyone's doubt."

The wait had been long. The pain had been deep.

Now he wanted to paint his name across this many-colored world. Not Cheon Taemin's. Not Jin Taekyung's.

Michael Silbert's.

Humanity ruled five oceans and six continents. It had named every living thing it knew, past and present.

Rabbits. Dogs. Cats. Horses. Dinosaurs…

But there were exceptions.

Some beings passed down from the distant past possessed forms beyond humanity's ability to comprehend and overwhelming power. It was difficult to explain them as anything else.

One such being was now bringing disaster upon humanity.

Goooooong.

A low cry reverberated in every direction.

Beneath deep waters filled with countless pieces of wreckage and mixed with blood, a gigantic mythical beast advanced with the waves, smashing and sweeping away everything that stood in its path.

Craaaack!

Some called it a crocodile. Others compared it to a whale.

In the end, humanity could find no way to define it. It was too enormous to be treated as a mere animal, and it possessed a mysterious power no one could explain.

So they called it a monster beyond explanation. Over the centuries, it acquired a name that meant this creature and no other.

Far away, amid human screams, that name rang out.

"Le—Leviathan!"

"This is an order! All B-rank Hunters and below, leave the battlefield immedia—"

WHOOOOOOM!

The shouts and screams vanished. A wave of overwhelming force swallowed and shattered everything in its path.

People. Buildings. Even the pitiful defensive Magic.

Grrrrr.

Leviathan let out a satisfied growl as waves dozens of meters[3083] high swept through the surrounding area.

It had been so long since it had awakened from that tiresome sleep. So long since it had rampaged to its heart's content.

Yes. That was the last time.

Leviathan remembered its master.

The Demon King Asmodeus.

The absolute ruler who had united the chaotic Demon Realm and brought every monster to heel.

[3083] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–300 ft.

Yet even Asmodeus had fallen to human hands. Leviathan had retreated into the deep sea and gone to sleep.

With its master gone, it could no longer obtain the vast quantities of magical power and food it once had. To survive until the day he returned, it had needed to conserve its strength.

And the wait had not been in vain.

It's changed. Nothing like it was when the Demon King was here, but it has changed.

Leviathan had still been uncertain when it awoke and crossed the ocean. The closer it came to this place, though, the more clearly it sensed the abundant magical power permeating the water, the land, the air.

And what, exactly, had awakened it.

…!

Leviathan's enormous eyes flashed.

In the deep waters that had become part of the sea, a powerful energy reached it from among countless pieces of wreckage and human corpses.

That's…

There was no mistaking it. The appetizing scent of a Magic Gem—the source of a monster's power.

One untouched by human hands, still holding all its original energy. A mass of pure magical power.

An excellent source of food, more than enough to replenish the strength it had expended, had been waiting for Leviathan in the human settlement.

So that's why.

Leviathan understood what had awakened it. The magical power now permeating the world, combined with something containing energy of that magnitude, had been enough.

Leviathan was the calamity and ruler of the sea. Starved by its long sleep, its body had responded to the pulse of power carried through the seawater.

If I can make that magical power mine…

Greed filled Leviathan's eyes. A feast lay before it. Why refuse?

Whoooooosh.

Leviathan surged forward.

The water grew shallower as it advanced toward its prey, exposing part of its back. The beast did not hesitate.

It had already assessed the situation. The humans in its path were weak, and all around it surged seawater that obeyed its will.

"It's coming!"

"Lightning mages, prepare!"

"Ranged units, fire!"

Fwish-fwish-fwish! Crackle!

Countless arrows and lightning spells streaked through the air. The hastily assembled Hunters poured every ounce of strength into their volley.

The result was dismal.

BOOM-BOOM-BOOM!

The explosions cleared. The Hunters stared.

“What the…?”

A little scorching. Dozens of wounds.

No. Scratches.

That was the full extent of the damage they had inflicted on the monster before them. And the price that returned moments later was harsh.

Whoooosh—BOOM!

An enormous tail broke the surface and struck the water.

The tanks at the front clenched their teeth as a wave rose with a thunderous roar. They planted their half-submerged legs and layered their Tower Shields into a wall.

Clack-clack-clack!

Their movements were vigorous and as fast as lightning.

Fewer than a hundred Hunters remained, but every one of them was at least B-rank. They were seasoned fighters. They knew their duty.

“Formaaaaation!”

“Don’t fall back! Hold!”

“Protect us from the enemy, Great Shield!”

The tanks’ desperate shouts mingled with the mages’ incantations.

Then Leviathan spoke in a Demon Realm language none of them understood.

“Get lost.”

The enormous wave rising around it surged forward and split.

Splaash!

One wave became dozens. Dozens became hundreds of streams. Charged with powerful magical power, they took the shape of spears and fell upon the Hunters.

KABOOOOOM!

A shock wave arrived with a thunderous roar and shook everything around them.

Hundreds of spears made of water and magical power tore through the layered defensive Magic and crushed the Tower Shields standing before them like an iron wall.

Crack! Thunk-thunk-thunk!

“Urgh…!”

The water spears swallowed even the screams as they smashed armor and cut through flesh and bone.

The streams ran red with blood. As Hunters crumpled beneath them, a fierce wind swept overhead.

Tat-tat-tat-tat-tat!

Propellers churned.

Dozens of unmanned fighter jets broke through the storm and immediately opened fire with their guns and missiles.

Destroy Leviathan?

No one dreamed of it.

Their only goal was to hold the monster up, however briefly, until the main force capable of fighting it arrived.

But contrary to the hopes of those watching the scene from the operations control room, Leviathan's power and authority were simply too overwhelming.

Gooooooong.

The ancient beast that commanded tidal waves and storms roared. Lightning fell from the cloud-choked sky and swept through the unmanned jets.

Rrrrrumble—BOOM!

They crashed. Exploded. Sank.

At the center of the calamity, Leviathan drove its enormous body onward.

Its long sleep and the considerable magical power it had spent had left it slightly tired. None of that mattered.

That mass of magical power was drawing closer by the moment. Its scent was so appetizing it nearly overwhelmed Leviathan's reason.

With it, Leviathan could regain its former strength. Cover this land with a tidal wave and claim it for its own.

Grrrrraaaah.

At last, with its prey before it, Leviathan opened its jaws wide.

Its crocodile-like maw swept toward the corpses and wreckage submerged in the deep water—and the mass of magical power hidden somewhere among them—to swallow everything in one bite.

It would have.

If not for a streak of light that descended onto the rippling surface of the water.

Fwooooooosh! Craaaack!

Blue-white light-flames, burning with tremendous heat, consumed the wave.

Chapter 749

Leviathan was both the calamity and the king of the sea.

That was true in the Demon Realm and on Earth alike.

The sea was Leviathan's birthplace, a battlefield where it had never known defeat. Within that vast territory, granted to it at birth, nothing could escape the king's watch.

Or so it should have been.

Fwooooooosh!

In an instant, the monster stopped, its prey before it and greed filling its thoughts. At the same time, Leviathan's senses, numbed by its long starvation, awakened.

What is this?

When had it begun?

As realization struck, the world seemed to slow. Leviathan could see and feel it clearly now.

A mighty force, swift as lightning and carrying the heat of the sun.

The flames plunging down and swallowing the blue surface were headed straight for it.

Splaaash!

There was no time to hesitate.

The enormous maw it had opened to swallow its prey turned sharply underwater. An instant later, Leviathan bit down on the flames with hundreds of teeth imbued with magical power.

It had no doubt it would crush them.

Krrrk!

Then flame met teeth, and an impact strong enough to rattle its skull struck.

Krrrrrrk!

"…!"

What?

Leviathan's enormous eyes widened in pain and shock.

The teeth that had sunk dozens of aircraft carriers during the Great Cataclysm—those sharp, destructive weapons—had shattered in a single blow.

How? How is this possible?

Leviathan froze, unable to make sense of it.

Then the countless bubbles stirred up by the collision scattered, revealing the cause.

A spear.

Gooooong.

The silver spear trembled, wreathed in flames that refused to go out even amid the water and waves.

As though it were alive. As though it liked the touch of the hand holding it.

And through the owner of that spear flowed the blood of a species Leviathan had killed countless times.

“How can a mere human…!”

At the cry of the mythical beast, filled with undisguised astonishment, the small and insignificant human answered by merely moving his lips.

One Annihilation.

A distant flash of light dyed the sea.

People often say that life comes down to one big shot.

I agree. Especially since going for that one shot can be exactly how you throw your life away.

Rrrrrumble!

A thunderous roar, as if the sky—or rather, the sea—were splitting apart.

A tremendous shock wave sent my spent body flying. Swept up in a swirling current, I heard warnings sound again and again as my vision faded.

Beep. Beep-beep!

SYSTEM

You have exhausted all your internal energy and stamina!
Your body cannot withstand the recoil of One Annihilation!
Status abnormality, Internal Energy Depletion, has been applied!
Status abnormality, Exhaustion, has been applied!
Status abnormality, Anemia, has been applied!
Status abnormality, Muscle Tear, has been applied!
Status abnormality, Internal Injury, has been applied!
Warning! Warning! Remember that every action comes with a price!
Excessive use of power may turn into a blade against you.
Special debuff, Broken Body, has been applied!
All combat-related attributes decrease by 50 until recovery! Depending on how recovery goes, you may permanently lose some attributes!
Strength temporarily decreases by 50!
Agility...

.

.

.

High risk, high return.

That was exactly it.

As I grew stronger, the power of One Annihilation had risen exponentially—until even this nearly perfect body, one that people in Murim might mistake for a Heavenly Martial Physique, could no longer withstand it.

Damn it.

I was dizzy. My breathing was ragged.

My body had gone beyond exhaustion and was screaming in agony. My dantian, dry as a desert, begged me to stop.

The backlash was so severe I could not move a finger.

But if I had not anticipated a situation like this, I would never have attempted something as insane as firing One Annihilation in the first place.

Open Inventory. Summon.

The System responded to my thought. A silhouette appeared in my blurred vision, and someone's curt voice rang inside my head.

"You look awful. It suits you perfectly."

I never thought I would be so glad to hear that rude tone.

Seeing me grin despite the pain, the Skeleton King clicked his tongue and shoved a small crystal bottle into my mouth.

A solution available only in this world.

A treasure known as a Top-Grade Potion.

Gulp.

The moment I managed to swallow it, a refreshing energy spread through every part of my body.

Ding!

SYSTEM

You have used Top-Grade Potion!
All status abnormalities have been removed!

My empty dantian filled to the brim. My torn muscles knitted back together, and my hazy vision became clear and sharp.

Healing power on par with a Level Up.

But the warning that followed caught even me off guard.

Beep!

SYSTEM

The special debuff, Broken Body, rejects the effect!
This debuff cannot be removed by artificial means!
The effects of Broken Body remain active!

...What the hell?

For a moment, I was thrown by something I had never experienced before. But I had no time to work out what the warning meant.

The fight was not over.

Grrrrrrrrrrr!

A roar rang out, clear even underwater.

Leviathan's enormous body writhed in pain. Not even the countless wrecks and corpses sunk deep beneath the sea could conceal it.

KABOOOOOM!

It was some distance away, but I could see how badly it had been hurt.

The maw said to have once torn an aircraft carrier apart in a single bite had been ripped halfway off, along with one eye. Green blood poured from its flank, where

hide and bone had been stripped away, staining the water for hundreds of meters[3084] around it.

Even so, the monster had been incredibly lucky.

If it had not instinctively turned its head at the last moment—and if this had been land instead of underwater—it would have met its end long ago.

I should have finished it with one strike.

A shame, but there was nothing I could do about it.

My opponent was Leviathan, the calamity of the sea.

They say even a mutt has the advantage in its own yard. Fighting a creature born in the sea, one that had ruled it ever since, was several times harder underwater than fighting the Arch Lich.

But…

I'll kill it. I have to.

Splaaaaash!

The Skeleton King and I shot forward together. The powerful current in our path did nothing to slow us.

I tightened my webbed hand around the spear shaft. The transparent webbing was an effect of the **Water Rescue Worker** Title I had earned by completing a Quest at Dongting Lake a few months ago.

It lasted only twenty-four hours each time I activated it. Worse, its clash with the **Scorching Yang Qi** I had learned reduced all my power by a full twenty percent. But the effect was worth the cost.

Fwooooooosh!

I moved as quickly as though I were using a movement technique on land.

Still howling in pain, Leviathan spotted us closing in and roared.

"GRAAAAAAAH!"

The instant it opened its half-torn maw as wide as it could—

Krrrk. Krrrrrk!

The flow of the water changed. Though there was not a breath of wind underwater, everything around us was sucked toward its maw as if caught in a tornado.

It was a scene worthy of a disaster.

But I did not stop. I planted a foot on a nearby piece of wreckage and kicked off, picking up speed.

Toward the mythical monster. Toward the immense magical power stirring within it.

Then—

[3084] Hundreds of meters is roughly hundreds to a few thousand feet; 200–900 m is about 660–3,000 ft.

Gooooong.

The water and wreckage gathering around Leviathan burst outward in a massive wave.

KRAAAAAAAASH!

Was this what the Breath of the Dragons that once existed felt like?

The wave, charged with tremendous magical power, shot forward and erased everything in its path.

“You treacherous human!”

The Skeleton King shouted urgently behind me.

I did not answer. Instead, I drew on the internal energy filling my lower dantian and set an undying flame in the blade of White Flame.

Sssssss!

Heat spread in every direction. The raging current and pressure seemed to melt away. An energy like molten lava took the place of the sea’s chill.

For this moment, at least, this space belonged to me alone.

Nothing else could intrude.

Cut.

With that single thought, I brought the spearhead down.

Blue-white flames stretched out like a snake and struck the enormous wave just before it hit me.

No. They cut it.

Shhk!

The wave split cleanly in half and scattered to either side.

In that instant, I saw Leviathan’s eye widen in shock.

Then I saw its enormous body swimming at unbelievable speed toward something in the distance—something giving off a chilling energy.

The Magic Gem!

Now I understood why the monster had suddenly reappeared after decades in hiding. What had drawn it to these islands.

“Stop it!”

The Skeleton King reached out a hand with a shout that sounded almost like a scream. Bones rose upward like a growing tree and forcefully pushed against the tips of my feet.

Bang!

A dull boom sounded as I shot forward, cutting through the current toward Leviathan.

GRAAAAAH! KRRRUNCH!

Its crocodile-like maw swallowed a massive tangle of wreckage: steel beams from what had once been a cargo ship, concrete from a collapsed building, and something tiny by comparison that held an energy more dangerous than any of it.

Crunch.

Leviathan chewed and swallowed everything in one bite, then turned its head.

Fear and mockery mingled in its eye as it watched me approach. Then it swam away faster than I had ever seen it move.

Not toward me or the Skeleton King. Toward the open sea it had come from.

"It'll take time to absorb the energy! Kill it before then!"

I heard the Skeleton King's shout and gripped White Flame in reverse.

Barely a hundred meters[3085] separated us. But no matter how effective the **Water Rescue Worker** Title was, I could not match Leviathan's speed.

Once. Just once.

I gathered every bit of internal energy I had left and poured it into the spearhead.

This time… I'll finish it.

I focused. I felt the flow of the water and steadied my breathing. Every nerve and muscle seemed to come alive, the force of them gathering in my fingertips and shoulder.

Krrrrrk.

The veins across my body stood out.

Then, like releasing a bowstring drawn taut, I hurled the spear with all my strength.

KRAAAAAAAASH!

A single line of flame streaked through the deep water.

But no scream from the monster followed.

[3085] A hundred meters is about 330 ft.

Chapter 750

Deep beneath the sea.

Countless wrecks and corpses darkened the water until it was impossible to see an inch ahead. Then blue-white flames erupted.

Fwoosh! KRAAAAAASH!

The current split, and the water vaporized.

The flames carried an energy that defied the laws of nature. No—a spear shot forward like a ray of light.

Toward the enormous shadow moving at an unbelievable speed.

Toward a calamity that could never be allowed to live.

But the mythical monster defied the laws of nature just as surely as the energy in the spear did.

KRRRRRUMBLE!

The sea shook.

At the same time, large and small whirlpools of water surged up from the depths and blocked the spearhead as it raced forward.

KOOOOONG!

The collision sent waves of force spreading outward, one after another.

By the time the shock and thunderous roar that had shaken the world had subsided, the flames that had pulverized every obstacle in their path were also fading away, having exhausted their strength.

The spear had failed to reach the monster before its body vanished into the darkness far ahead.

Swish. Clack.

The sea had already grown quiet.

Someone caught the spear as it drifted helplessly with the current.

The man stood with his back to me, staring silently in the direction the monster had gone. He seemed ready to erupt like an active volcano.

No. Let me correct that.

He didn’t merely *seem* ready to erupt. One touch, and he would explode.

He’d been that way when the monster he could never allow to live had escaped.

And he was that way now.

“Enough.”

The instant the sharp voice slipped from my lips without my realizing it—

Flash.

A vivid green light spread through the water, and everything around me melted away.

The sea, dark as night. The enormous wreckage of high-rise buildings. Even the nameless corpses that had died with their eyes wide open.

In place of the vanished hologram, several dozen unfamiliar faces came into view.

Men in military uniforms and expensive-looking tailored suits.

The old man seated opposite me, at the head of the table, spoke with a grave expression.

“Good heavens. To think Leviathan got away.”

It was the first time I had seen his face, but according to Team Leader Choi, that old man was one of the three most powerful people in Japan.

No—if you counted the authority he actually wielded, he might be number one.

The position of Defense Minister was an immensely powerful one even in peacetime. In a situation like this, with the country at war, he possessed more power than anyone.

But looking at the old Defense Minister put me in a foul mood.

To be honest, I wanted to deal with that damned old man before Leviathan, who wasn’t even here.

Why? Simple.

An hour ago, he’d eliminated our last chance to catch it.

Now that I knew what had happened, I wasn’t about to be polite.

“Yeah. Shame it got away. If someone had helped at the end, we might have caught it.”

“…!”

The conference room went still. While the other Japanese men glanced nervously at one another, the Defense Minister fixed me with an offended stare.

“That sounds as though you’re blaming Japan. Or have my old ears misheard you?”

“I heard you were over eighty, but you’re still in good shape. Your hearing’s pretty sharp for an old man.”

“What?”

“Have your ears actually gotten worse? You already heard me, so why do you keep asking?”

“How dare—!”

Bang!

The Defense Minister slammed the table and turned to Team Leader Choi.

“Are you going to stand there and allow this insolence?”

Normally, Team Leader Choi would have given me a warning look by now.

Normally.

“By ‘insolence,‘ Defense Minister, do you mean striking the table during a meeting like this?”

"What?"

"Japan formally requested assistance through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. We answered that request and risked our lives to come here. And yet…"

Team Leader Choi's words cut off, and his gaze turned cold.

"Why did you not deploy additional forces?"

"…"

"As I understand it, at the exact moment Jin Taekyung attacked Leviathan, at least two thousand Hunters had been mobilized. The Ground and Air Self-Defense Forces were also standing by."

"That was…"

"I know most of them would not have been much help in a fight. But if you had deployed Japan's Hunters, even then, they could have slowed Leviathan's escape for a little while."

Team Leader Choi's words were clear and precise. They were also entirely true.

That little while was exactly what I'd needed.

A bit of support—and sacrifice—to distract the wounded monster and delay it as it dragged itself away.

Instead, after risking my life to go down into that deep water, I'd had to watch its back grow smaller in the distance.

Team Leader Choi and the roughly two hundred Hunters who'd disembarked from the aircraft and were preparing to enter had been forced to watch it escape, too.

"I could no longer stand by, so I tried to lead the Hunters in myself. Your side stopped us. You even invoked your authority over field operations."

"…!"

"If you wanted to keep your own losses down and claim the credit, you should have done the job properly. Then we wouldn't be in this situation."

The Defense Minister clenched his lips tightly before speaking.

"The encirclement… The encirclement was perfect."

The Skeleton King looked at me with genuine curiosity.

"If it was perfect, shouldn't Leviathan have failed to break through?"

"Yeah. It should have."

"But it broke through?"

"Yep."

"And you lost track of it because of the magical power it released?"

"Yep."

Having listened to all my helpful answers, the Skeleton King muttered, "What? Are they fucking idiots…?"

"…!"

"…!"

With that single statement striking the truth with perfect accuracy, the temperature inside the conference room dropped below freezing.

But watching everyone fall silent and glance nervously around gave me no satisfaction at all.

Fucking lunatics.

Those bugs were worse than monsters, and they were sitting there calling themselves the operation's command staff. I couldn't even laugh.

It's not like I can say "fuck this" and quit.

The number of casualties confirmed so far was roughly one hundred thousand.

It was only that low because, by some stroke of luck, the tsunami Leviathan had caused had stopped around the outskirts of Tokyo.

If it returned after I left, Tokyo would be renamed Atlantis.

And if it gives up on Japan and goes after somewhere else…

That would be a problem too.

Of course, the idiots here—including that old monkey chief—would probably dance for joy because *they'd* survived.

"…"

The worst part was, they really would.

After letting out a hundred-percent pure, deep sigh, I spoke to the Defense Minister, who had become completely silent.

"Enough. Get me someone else in charge."

"S-someone else?"

"The Prime Minister. Or the King of Japan. Whoever it is, they'll be better than you."

"The King of Japan? How dare you speak of His Majesty the Emperor of the Great Japanese Empire—"

"Oh, give me a break. How long are you going to keep up the empire crap? Your empire got flattened by two atomic bombs. You should've given up the title of Emperor while you were at it."

"That was a savage and barbaric act of destruction by those American Yankees!"

I plugged my ears as the Defense Minister shrieked.

"I think I'm going to get radiation poisoning. I think I'm going to get radiation poisoning. I think I'm going to get radiation poisoning. I think I'm going to get radiation poisoning."

"Chikshō!"[3086]

Maybe he'd lived long enough not to care. Or maybe radiation contamination had robbed him of all fear.

[3086] Japanese *chikushō* is an exclamation meaning "damn it."

Just as the Defense Minister was rampaging and charging at me with his old body, the Skeleton King reached out and seized him by the back of the neck.

“Stop, you old and insignificant hu—no, Yellow Monkey.”

“You wretch! Release me at once! How dare a fur-covered Yankee lay a hand on the Defense Minister of the Great Japanese Empire!”

“You dare insult the great United States in front of me?”

“I have not forgotten the terrible things you bastards did to this land and its innocent subjects of the Imperial State!”

Vengeful spirits of Pearl Harbor, descend upon me!

These fucking lunatics…

A Japanese imperialist from the ‘70s-and-’80s generation arguing with an American monster from the Demon Realm.

Watching those horrifying hybrids with my own two eyes made my chest swell with emotion despite itself, but it was not over yet.

Fwooooooosh.

“…?”

What the hell?

A chill ran through me, and the fluorescent lights began to dim.

Even the people struggling to separate the Defense Minister and the Skeleton King shuddered in the cold.

What the hell is happening all of a sudden?

I turned my head. My eyes met Team Leader Choi’s across the room.

That was when I realized it. My mouth fell open.

A shout from moments earlier rang through my ears again.

Vengeful spirits of Pearl Harbor, descend upon me!

No. Fuck. Don’t tell me…

Whooooooosh! KRAAASH!

The eerie energy became a gale, shattering the fluorescent lights overhead.

I was already running through the sudden darkness toward someone.

“Look closely, and feel their resentment—!”

“Hey, you crazy bastard!”

Crack!

Thank goodness.

Thanks to a time-honored promotion system that still valued family and connections over ability in the twenty-first century, most of the high-ranking

officials and generals in the conference room were ordinary people. They were too frightened even to hear the Skeleton King's shout.

And apparently my demand for someone in charge had gotten through. Before long, the manager—no, the Prime Minister—arrived.

"You came all this way to help our country! I am most grateful, Jinsang!"[3087]

"Ah, yes. Nice to meet you, Prime Minister Koizumi."

I had never imagined I would live to see the day I met this man in person.

I'd only ever seen collections of his quotes online. Seeing him now gave me a brief jolt of excitement, like I'd met a celebrity.

Of course, this wasn't the time to show it. We needed to deal with Leviathan.

At least, that was what I wanted to do.

I did.

"I'll get straight to the point. To track Leviathan—"

"I hear the Defense Minister was rude to you, Jinsang.[3088] Once this is over, I shall reprimand him severely, if only to ease your hurt feelings!"

"Uh. Thanks. I appreciate it."

"Why the look, Jinsang?"[3089]

"No, it's just… We also need to discuss Leviathan. And the way you keep addressing me is a little…"

"The way I address you, Jinsang?"[3090]

"…"

"Ah, I see. It must sound like something else in Korean. Then shall I call you Gyeongsang,[3091] using the last syllable of your name?"

There was no way that would work.

I'd dodged a pile of shit only to get pissed on.

Is he wishing me a minor injury next time I fight Leviathan…?

I weighed Jinsang[3092] against Gyeongsang,[3093] then sighed.

Well, at least it isn't Severe Injury.

[3087] Japanese *Jin-san* combines a name with the polite honorific *-san*. It sounds like Korean *jinsang*, meaning an obnoxious or troublesome person.

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Chapter 751

Unlike the lunatic imperialist serving as Defense Minister, Japan's prime minister proved surprisingly easy to reason with.

"I cannot remove the Defense Minister immediately, but I will grant you and the other Koreans independent operational authority, Jinsang[3094]."

"Please also guarantee us supplies and military support through the Defense Ministry," Team Leader Choi said, polite but firm. "We came at your country's request to cooperate, not to be sacrificed."

The prime minister nodded. "Agreed. I shall do everything within my power."

If it were up to me, I'd dunk the idiots at the Defense Ministry in a radioactive hot spring. Even that wouldn't be enough.

But what could we do? The damage was done. We had to make the best of what we had.

"How, though, do you intend to deal with a monster that has already escaped?" the prime minister asked.

"I have a way."

The answer came out of nowhere. The Skeleton King was staring at the prime minister with his usual arrogant glare. I made a throat-cutting gesture at him, and he flinched.

"I have a way, yo," he corrected himself.

That was a form of polite speech found in no family tree, but the prime minister—already famous for his collection of memorable quotes—didn't seem to mind. If anything, he looked pleased.

"Ah, Stomu-King. I have heard much about you."

"Me? I mean… me, sir?"

"Of course. I knew of you even before this incident, when you helped suppress several mutation Gates in Korea."

The Skeleton King had been known here and there among the public even before the vigilante incident came to light. The appearance of a previously unknown top-tier Hunter had briefly drawn attention, but the story was soon buried.

Magic Johnson had done a thorough job of laundering his identity. Besides, the truth was so ridiculous that no one had suspected he might be a monster.

…Actually, I just took so much shit that nobody paid attention to him.

"It is a pleasure to meet you at last, Stomu-King."

The Skeleton King had been looking rather proud that a country's prime minister knew who he was. Now his brow furrowed.

[3094] Japanese *-san* is a polite honorific. Korean *jinsang* means an obnoxious or difficult person; the similar sounds allow the address to become an insult.

“The pleasure is mine. But I am—no, my name is Stone King.”

“Yes, that is what I am calling you. Stomu-King.”

“I said Stone King. Here, repeat after me slowly. S. Tone. King.”

“S. Tone. King.”

“Now a little longer. Stone. King.”

“Stone. King.”

“Excellent! Now put it together.”

“Stomu-King.”

“Good heavens. I’m going to lose my mind. I can’t believe this! What is wrong with your tongue?”

The cursed archipelago’s pronunciation system had met Demon Realm mangled-speech in a collaboration for the ages.

Team Leader Choi squeezed his eyes shut. Unable to watch any more, I stepped in.

“Enough. Stone King, Stomu-King, stalking—what difference does it make?”

“It makes a tremendous difference, you Jinsang[3095] bastard!”

“More difference than the crack I’m about to put in your skull?”

“Hmm. On second thought, perhaps not.”

“See?”

“Of course. Call me whatever you like. That can be my name.”

“Good attitude, Fucking. Now tell us how to track Leviathan.”

The Skeleton King muttered a curse at his new name, then spoke.

“First, your premise is wrong. We shouldn’t track Leviathan. We need to lure it as close to land as we can.”

“Lure it?”

“Yes. The sea is entirely its territory. Try to follow it with some half-baked scheme, and we may lose it for good.”

“You mean…”

“It was too badly wounded to flee far. Leviathan can’t have gone far yet.”

Team Leader Choi raised a question. “Although Leviathan suffered a heavy blow thanks to Mr. Jin Taekyung, I understand that it obtained an unrefined S-rank Magic Gem. Wouldn’t that be enough for it to recover from its wounds and then some?”

“Heal?”

The Skeleton King gave a quiet snort.

[3095] Japanese *-san* is a polite honorific. Korean *jinsang* means an obnoxious or difficult person; the similar sounds allow the address to become an insult.

“Leviathan could absorb all the magical power in that gem, however much it holds. But even once it makes that power its own, completely healing its injuries is another matter.”

“Hmm.”

“It would need more magical power to heal wounds like those. By now, it must have realized that too.”

The assessment from an actual monster was persuasive.

On top of that, One Annihilation was a killing blow powerful enough to wreck even its caster’s body.

True to its name, Leviathan had twisted its body at the last moment, but those were not wounds that could heal in a short time.

Lure it. Lure it, huh.

I turned the word over in my mind. “It sized up the situation, took exactly what it wanted, and ran. Would something that cunning fall for a trap?”

The answer was simple.

“It will, if the conditions are right.”

“So we set a trap it has no choice but to enter, even knowing it’s a trap?”

“Think of Leviathan as a hungry, wounded beast. Hunger brought it here in the first place.”

Team Leader Choi spoke almost with a groan. “We’ll need one hell of a lure.”

“Yes. We need bait so delicious that Leviathan will risk its life to charge at it.”

And at this point, there was only one thing that could lure Leviathan in.

“Excuse me, Prime Minister?”

Koizumi had been following the conversation with glazed eyes. He looked up at my gentle tone.

“Ah, yes. Go ahead.”

“Does Japan happen to have a few of those?”

“A few of what?”

“Don’t play dumb. S-rank Magic Gems.”

“…Eh?”

“Let us borrow them for a bit.”

“…Ehhh?”

“Why so surprised? We’ll catch Leviathan and give them back. Promise.”

I held out my pinkie to the wide-eyed prime minister.

We’ll win one and pay it back. Win it.

In the modern world, S-rank Magic Gems were treasures of tremendous value.

Before even considering that they were the finest energy source capable of powering an entire metropolis, there were only around a hundred of them in the entire world. Their rarity alone was astonishing.

Perhaps that was why the Japanese prime minister, despite promising his full cooperation, had initially been horrified. Of course, in the end, he had no choice but to hand them over, even if it was against his will.

"Here they are."

Click.

The security Magic disengaged, and a soft velvet box opened. Inside lay two Magic Gems, shedding brilliant light.

"Hmm. Only two?"

The prime minister saw my expression and answered in a rush. "These are all the S-rank Magic Gems the Japanese government owns."

"Really?"

"Not a word of a lie! Do you know how hard I had to work to persuade the cabinet and His Majesty the Emperor?"

"If I search the place and find more, that's one S-rank Magic Gem for every—"

"…Mr. Jin Taekyung?" Team Leader Choi said.

"Oh. Sorry. Force of habit."

Habits are scary.

At Team Leader Choi's intervention, I scratched the back of my head. The Japanese prime minister, who had been edging backward for a while now, hurriedly slipped out of the room, repeatedly begging us to return the Magic Gems safely.

But once he was gone, the mood in the room was rather lukewarm.

"Hmm. Two…"

"Not quite enough."

"I agree," the Skeleton King said. "They still hold a considerable amount of magical power, but not enough to lure Leviathan."

The number of S-rank Magic Gems didn't matter. What mattered was the amount and quality of the magical power left in them.

Normally, they should obviously have been refined… but this time, we have a different use for them.

We had two S-rank Magic Gems in front of us. What we needed was bait—something Leviathan would rush for even if it knew there was a trap.

A massive mass of pure magical power, like the one it had taken.

Even if we use both of these together as bait, they still won't come close to an unrefined Magic Gem.

I wasn't alone in thinking it. As we exchanged looks, the Skeleton King spoke up.

“No matter how I think about it, these will not be enough. What about bringing more?”

“Bring more from where…? Oh.”

I remembered Area A, hidden inside Ares Guild headquarters. The place had held staggering amounts of cash, artwork, and Magic Gems—including five S-rank Magic Gems.

“But those were refined too.”

“That… is true.”

The Skeleton King smacked his lips. “Still, better than nothing. Is there no way to get them?”

They were better than nothing, but adding five more wouldn’t change much. The more thoroughly a Magic Gem was refined, the more valuable it became, and the S-rank gems Lee Jungryong and Go Jun had stashed in Area A were top of the line.

There was another problem: the owner had the final say.

“They were probably acquired through illegal channels to begin with,” Team Leader Choi said. “If word gets out, the media will have a field day.”

Especially now. It’d turn into a fucking shitshow. Camera-toting hyenas were everywhere, ready to pounce at the first opening.

The Skeleton King thought for a moment. “Then what about gathering unrefined Magic Gems? If we collect everything coming out of the nearby Gates and bring it here—”

I beamed and patted his shoulder.

“Congratulations. You’ve been sentenced to life in prison for violating international law.”

“Goddamn it!”

“Welcome to the bright and cheerful twenty-first century. It’s surprisingly fucking hard to live here.”

Crack.

The Skeleton King ground his teeth. “Then we have no choice. We use those gems as bait, or we assemble a raid team from our strongest fighters, track Leviathan down, and kill it ourselves.”

“Wow, what a time to be alive. A monster suggesting a raid against another monster.”

“What else can we do?”

What else, huh?

I exchanged a covert glance with Team Leader Choi. Then, watching the Skeleton King’s temper, I spoke carefully.

“I didn’t say there was no other way.”

“What?”

“There is one.”

His face lit up. “What is it?”

“Before I tell you, you need to know something. If we form a raid team… you’re sitting this one out.”

“Leaving me out? What are you talking about?”

It must have been more unexpected than he could have imagined. I continued as he stared at me with perfectly round eyes.

“I can’t help it. Too many people are watching us right now.”

He wasn’t stupid. His face hardened as he caught my meaning.

“You’re leaving me out of the fight with Leviathan because my power might give me away?”

“You got it.”

“Have you lost your mind? How can you say that now?”

Bang! Crunch!

His fist came down, shattering the table. Suddenly he was right in front of me, his eyes full of anger and disappointment.

“You treacherous human. I was wrong about you. How could you say such a thing at a time like this?”

“What does it matter? You’re a monster.”

“…What?”

“Even if we catch Leviathan, once your identity is revealed, you’re finished. I’m only trying to avoid that.”

Wood crackle.

Bones shifted in his clenched fist. He stared at me in disbelief, then cried out as if the words were blood he had to spit up.

“I don’t care! If I can save them, I’ll do anything! Leviathan caused this disaster, and—”

“Anything?”

“Huh?”

Got you. Hooked.

I looked at the Skeleton King with a satisfied smile.

“You said you’d do anything. Right?”

Chapter 752

Leviathan.

The nightmare of the sea had slowly faded from memory. News of its return drew more attention worldwide than any of the other Monster Waves that day.

[Breaking News: Leviathan Appears—Disaster Descends on Japan]

[The Star of Asia, Jin Taekyung, Saves Japan Despite the Suspicions Surrounding Him; Wounded Leviathan Disappears]

[Anonymous Senior Japanese Official: “We Had a Real Chance to Kill Leviathan—If the Defense Minister Hadn’t Suddenly Shit Himself.” Complacency at Japan’s Defense Ministry?]

[Casualties Confirmed So Far Reach 100,000. The Archipelago in Crisis.]

[Japanese Defense Minister Fujiwara: “I Will Risk My Life to Protect the Imperial Subjects—No, the Citizens.” The True Feelings of an Imperialist Who Can’t Keep Up with the Times?]

[Japanese Defense Minister Fujiwara Leaves the Press Conference as Though Fleeing (Photo)]

[Japanese Prime Minister Vows: “We Will Kill That Monster Within Three Days and Show the Archipelago’s Strength.” Asked How by a Foreign Reporter, He Smiles Faintly: “We Will Succeed. That Is My Promise.”]

[Japanese Netizens Speak as One: “Please, Someone Shut the Prime Minister’s Mouth.”]

[The Young Hero from the Peninsula Who Saved the Archipelago. But Light and Shadow Surround Him.]

[Chinese Chairman Xiao Yang: “Mr. Jin Is a True Hero. Only Cowardly, Narrow-Minded Petty Men Would Insult Him.”]

[Operator of China’s Biggest Anti–Jin Taekyung Website Arrested by Public Security. The Charge? Being a Petty Man.]

[Leviathan Disappears Once Again. Terrorist Attacks and Monster Waves Continue.]

[Michael Silbert and Odin Guild Suppress a Third Monster Wave in a Single Day. Praise Pours in from Around the World, Along with Questions About Sky: “Why Hasn’t He Appeared?”]

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Tap.

Huginn set down his tablet.

Just as I thought. This isn’t good.

Public opinion was slowly shifting. Japan's Defense Ministry was taking the blame for letting Leviathan escape, and even the outlets that had rushed to attack Jin Taekyung were quietly changing their tune.

What if Jin Taekyung actually kills Leviathan now?

The damage their media campaign had done to his image could vanish in an instant. That would disrupt the plan they had prepared down to the last detail.

Huginn turned toward his superior. Michael Silbert, his back to him as he made coffee, spoke without looking around.

"The back of my head suddenly feels prickly. Is that just my imagination?"

"…Probably not."

"If you have something to say, say it. Unless it's about Jin Taekyung. Keep that to yourself."

Normally, Huginn would have obeyed. But the battle that had ended only thirty minutes ago still had his blood up, and he couldn't ignore how badly things seemed to be turning in Japan.

"Have you not heard the news?"

Michael gave a quiet laugh at the frustration in Huginn's voice and lifted his coffee cup.

"Huginn, my friend. Do you think you know something I don't?"

"Then why—"

"The coffee smells especially good today. Shall I make you a cup?"

"…Guild Master, if Jin Taekyung kills Leviathan, we'll have trouble afterward."

Click.

Michael set down his cup and leaned back against the leather sofa.

The inside of the tent, enchanted with spatial expansion, was as luxurious as a suite in a seven-star hotel. Michael seemed so relaxed that it was hard to believe he had defeated an S-rank monster only moments earlier.

"Huginn, I'll say this once. Listen carefully."

"Yes."

"There's nothing to worry about. All the conditions are in place, and Leviathan won't be so easily killed."

"But…"

"I want Jin Taekyung and Leviathan to give it everything they have. To struggle with all their might to kill each other and stay alive. That's all I want."

"…!"

"Of course, if Jin Taekyung dies in the process, so much the better."

Michael winked at the bewildered Huginn and reached for the cup he had set down.

Click. Splash.

Coffee spilled across the table, steam rising from it.

Huginn, lost in thought, looked up in surprise.

“Are you all right?”

“…”

“Guild Master?”

“Ah.”

Michael’s face had gone rigid as stone. Now it relaxed, and his usual calm expression returned.

“I’m fine. I suppose several hard battles have left me a little tired.”

But Huginn had served at his side for too many years to take that at face value. He glanced at Michael’s trembling fingers.

“You’ve been training too hard these past few months.”

“Have I?”

“Yes. Especially since you learned about Jin Taekyung, you’ve been…”

Huginn trailed off. Michael was watching him. He lowered his head.

“I spoke out of turn.”

A heavy silence fell between them. Michael broke it.

“Is the press conference ready?”

“Yes. They’ve been waiting for an hour.”

“We’ll begin in thirty minutes. We leave as soon as it’s over, so have everything ready by then.”

“Understood, Guild Master.”

Huginn answered without hesitation. He didn’t ask why they were leaving already, or where they were going. He would find out once the preparations were complete.

Another terrorist attack. Another Monster Wave. And somewhere, more glory and fame would be waiting for them.

In this cruelly well-crafted script, Odin Guild was always a step ahead, building a reputation that would never die.

“I’ll return to escort you shortly.”

Huginn bowed and left. Alone, Michael Silbert murmured, “You’re right, Huginn. Perhaps that’s exactly what it is.”

Jin Taekyung.

From the moment Michael had first learned of him, a feeling he couldn’t explain had filled his chest. Hazy as fog, it was impatience.

And anxiety.

An old memory surfaced: himself with nothing but ambition to his name, forced to lie low and stay out of Cheon Taemin’s sight. The humiliation of those days.

But…

“In the end, I’ll be the only one who wins.”

The words slipped from his lips in a low murmur.

Feeling the mighty energy coursing through his body, Michael Silbert was certain the day of his victory was near.

Whooooooosh.

The wind blowing from far away was thick with the smell of salt.

Near the Philippine Sea, close to the Japanese archipelago, a whale surfaced through the rolling water and blinked its enormous eyes.

The sea was strangely quiet today, even to a creature as vast as this one. It had roamed for hours without seeing a whaling ship—or even an ordinary fishing boat.

Pfooout.

The whale sent a spout of water into the air and dove deep again. Hundreds of schooling fish followed it.

Splash.

The creatures that had fallen in together swam on without rest.

Not farther away, but deeper, following a call from somewhere in the dark depths.

Goooong.

Hundreds became thousands, drawn from more and more species. Yet none of the sea creatures following that call sensed anything wrong.

Not even when a vast darkness unlike anything they had seen closed around them like a net.

GRAAAAAH. CRUNCH!

That was the end.

Teeth harder than steel tore the whale and sharks apart. Thousands of fish were sucked in. The monster opened its enormous jaws, chewed and swallowed everything, then savored the taste for a moment.

No. It absorbed every trace of energy and every memory they held.

Whooooooosh.

A dim light rose in the place known as the deep sea. But even after taking in that new energy, the monster’s eyes were full of hunger.

That’s all?

It hadn’t been like this when it roamed the five oceans at its master’s command. From the moment the Demon King Asmodeus descended, the whole world—land and sea alike—had been full of delectable magical power. Even the smallest fish had carried a little of it.

Now everything was different.

Its once-great master was gone. The monster that had ruled every sea in the world had been forced to hide from human eyes in the deep sea once more, gravely wounded.

Hisssss.

Green blood seeped from its unhealed wounds and mingled with the seawater. Leviathan's enormous body shuddered with rage.

How dare… How dare a mere human…

But rage wasn't all it felt.

Fear.

That loathsome feeling, born of an impossibly small human, held the mighty monster captive in the deep sea.

What are you? How can a lowly human possess such power?

Leviathan couldn't understand it.

Over the course of roughly a day, Leviathan had completely absorbed the masses of magical power that humans called S-rank Magic Gems.

It had been certain that the healing power of water, combined with the new magical power, would make any injury vanish without a trace. Yet everything had gone as badly as it could.

The moment I leave the deep sea, the humans will target me. Better to gather as much strength as I can here before I go…

Then its enormous eye stopped roving.

Unfamiliar memories, memories that weren't its own, had flashed through its mind.

What's this?

The question lasted only an instant. The memories of the countless sea creatures it had just swallowed surged into its mind like waves.

Blue sky. A calm sea without a single fishing boat.

And…

What is that?

A small boat bobbed on waters that, only hours ago, had been full of human warships and submarines. The image came from a school of fish that had seen it an hour earlier, near an uninhabited island a few hundred kilometers[3096] away.

Too close. And the sea has gone too quiet.

Leviathan knew at once that the humans had set a trap, and scoffed.

Fools. Do they think they can deceive me—

[3096] A few hundred kilometers is roughly 120–310 mi.

The thought broke off. Leviathan turned its head toward the surface above. All five of its senses sharpened at an alluring scent carried down through the water.

Magical power. An enormous amount of it.

A fierce craving seized its entire body.

If I had that… If I could take that power, greater even than what I absorbed before, these wounds would be nothing.

I could kill the human who humiliated me in an instant.

Muttering as if entranced, Leviathan ground its teeth.

I mustn't be swayed. It's clearly a human trap.

But its resolve soon crumbled.

The memories showed no humans anywhere. Nor did the information reaching it through the water now.

I can't sense the life force unique to humans. In that case…

Leviathan made its decision. It would go willingly into the trap they had prepared.

Splash!

Its enormous body surged upward, cutting through the currents of the deep sea.

Chapter 753

The man looked around.

What wonderful weather. Only a little over twenty hours ago, the sea had been bucking like mad. Now it was calm, and gulls flew in flocks across the clear sky.

Beautiful. Is this nature?

The place where the man had lived was nothing like this. That distant, distant place was always dim and dark as night, with a terrible stench hanging in the air. Of course, for personal reasons, he had never smelled a stench in his life, but there was no doubt the place had reeked.

In any case, the man liked this world.

He could see beautiful scenery he had never seen before. Better yet, he was with some pretty decent people.

"…"

On second thought, he should probably exclude one of them.

No, two.

The man—the Skeleton King—remembered a conversation from a few hours earlier.

"Anything?"

"Huh?"

"You said you'd do anything, right?"

"Huh?"

"My goodness. Such a noble spirit of sacrifice. As battalion commander, I am genuinely moved."

"Spirit of sacrifice? What are you talking about?"

"Shh. Enough. I know. I know how you feel, so stop pretending."

Holy shit…?

Something felt off.

Things were taking a strange turn.

He looked desperately to the other human for help, but the one he had thought was at least somewhat sane turned out to be in on it too.

"Hey, handsome and intelligent human…"

"Please don't speak to me. I'm too overcome to answer right now."

"You son of a bitch…"

"I see you in a new light, Mr. King. Sacrificing yourself for the greater good…"

"I never said I'd sacrifice myself, so why do you keep saying that…?"

"We will never forget your sacrifice. You are a true hero."

"Stop! Why are you coming closer?"

By the time he realized this was more than strange—that he was in danger—it was too late.

Jin Taekyung had blocked the door and was creeping toward him with a bundle of rope.

“I’ll talk to you carefully. I’ll try to find my courage.”

“Don’t sing some weird song! Put down the rope!”

“Starting today, I want to make you my bait.”

“What song has lyrics like that? Don’t rewrite it!”

“Team Leader Choi, why aren’t you grabbing him? Am I the only bad guy here?”

“Ah, my apologies. I was wiping away my tears.”

“Get the hell away from me!”

Splash! Rattle!

A wave rolled in from far away and struck the stern of the little motorboat.

The seawater splashed refreshingly across his face, jolting the Skeleton King out of his thoughts. He muttered,

“…Damn it.”

Naturally, resisting had been pointless.

The humans he had trusted had boxed him in from the front and rear, while Jin Taekyung—the root of all evil—made a solemn declaration like a judge delivering a verdict.

“Don’t make a fuss. Become bait quietly, and there won’t be a boneshed.”

“Isn’t it supposed to be bloodshed?”

“He doesn’t have any blood.”

“Oh.”

“So, what’ll it be?”

What else could he do?

The die had already been cast, and the hustlers had loaded it.

Realizing that he had fallen into the trap before Leviathan, the Skeleton King chose to avoid a boneshed and obediently boarded the little boat.

Along with the two S-rank Magic Gems the Japanese government had provided.

“Get rid of these cumbersome things. The monster will drool over me even without them.”

“No, no. Do you eat samgyeopsal[3097] without ssamjang[3098] and scallion salad?”

“…Is it already decided that Leviathan’s going to eat me?”

“Don’t worry. We’ll save you when it’s time to dip you in the ssamjang[3099].”

“What if it swallows me in one bite?”

[3097] Samgyeopsal is grilled pork belly.

[3098] Ssamjang is a savory Korean dipping paste commonly served with grilled meat.

[3099] Ssamjang is a savory Korean dipping paste commonly served with grilled meat.

"Wow. That would be delicious."

"…You are going to save me, right?"

"I suddenly feel like having some soju.[3100] Don't you, Team Leader Choi?"

"I prefer wine, but soju[3101] definitely goes with samgyeopsal.[3102]"

"You're definitely going to save me… right?"

That was the last thing he heard.

The little boat, carrying one S-rank monster and two S-rank Magic Gems, set off before he received an answer. Following GPS coordinates entered beforehand, it began circling near an uninhabited island several hundred kilometers[3103] away.

It had been circling for an hour now, waiting for the big one hiding somewhere in the deep sea to take the bait.

"You damn humans."

The Skeleton King gazed up at the blue sky and felt his nonexistent heart pounding.

What if the monster really shows up?

He knew exactly how great the difference in strength was between him and Leviathan.

Unlike his former self, who had not even possessed reason, Leviathan had been born a predator, endowed with immense magical power from the start. They were fundamentally different.

Among the S-rank monsters known in the Demon Realm as the "Seventy-Two Legion Commanders," Leviathan had ranked in the top ten.

Though its strength had waned since those days, the fear lodged in the Skeleton King's heart would not go away so easily.

Don't come. Don't come. Please don't come…

The Skeleton King liked this world.

Unlike him, already dead, nature was full of life. Cities were filled with dazzling, wondrous things, and there were human women of breathtaking beauty.

The way certain humans behaved occasionally disgusted him, but most were decent enough. He was even growing used to the word *friend*, which had seemed so strange at first.

But he had no desire to become nourishment for Leviathan.

He nearly cried at the thought of himself turned into a hearty samgyeopsal[3104] set meal.

You damn humans, please let me live too!

[3100] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.
[3101] Soju is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.
[3102] Samgyeopsal is grilled pork belly.
[3103] Each 100 kilometers is about 62 miles.
[3104] Samgyeopsal is grilled pork belly.

The fact that he could not even shout for fear of attracting Leviathan made him more miserable still. But it was far too late to turn back.

The Skeleton King touched the ssamjang[3105] and scallion salad hanging around his neck.

No—the two S-rank Magic Gems.

He glared at the sea.

Right. You only die once, not twice.

Repeating that phrase humans liked to use, he felt courage well up from somewhere inside him.

Besides, unlike humans, he really had died before. He had nothing left but bones, so perhaps he could survive being chewed a few times. Getting stuck between Leviathan's teeth would be even better.

"Come on, you monster! I'll take you on!"

And at the very moment the Skeleton King let out that brave shout—

Zzzzt. Splat.

Something fell from the sky onto his head and shoulder.

The Skeleton King rubbed the sticky, stark-white stuff with a bewildered look, then scowled.

Shit.

Warm bird shit.

"I ought to pluck every last feather off those bastards."

Growling under his breath, the Skeleton King looked up.

As expected, a flock of gulls had been circling above him for some time. They had apparently decided that humans were free cafeterias and had been following the little boat.

More precisely, they were scattering shit and piss as they flew away toward some distant point.

"They've got a damn good sense for—"

The Skeleton King broke off. His pupils trembled.

His eyes widened at the sight of birds flying in from the opposite direction, blackening the sky.

Birds? All of those?

While he stared with his mouth hanging open, thousands—perhaps tens of thousands—of birds, so many species mixed together that even an ornithologist would have struggled to tell them apart, flew over his head, following the gulls into the distance.

No.

[3105] Ssamjang is a savory Korean dipping paste commonly served with grilled meat.

That wasn’t it.

They were…

Fleeing.

As the word flashed through his mind, the calm sea began to heave.

Rrrrrumble!

A vibration rose from deep beneath the sea.

And then—

Whoooosh!

A triangular wave surged upward as if to swallow the world, a massive shadow undulating within it.

“GRAAAAAAAH!”

A savage roar shook the Philippine Sea.

The moment the mythical monster, more than three hundred meters[3106] long, opened its jaws toward the feast laid out on the tiny boat—

“It’s been twenty-three hours, you motherfucker.”

Along with the unexpected voice of one man, a fierce flame shot forward, evaporating the moisture in its path.

Crunch!

There is a martial art in Murim called the Turtle Breath Technique.

Strictly speaking, it is more of a method than a martial art. It suppresses breathing and heartbeat as much as possible, and even lowers body temperature.

In other words, it is a strange way of hiding all signs of life for a while. It also requires considerable internal energy and martial prowess, so few people in Murim learn it.

If you knew anything about the strange creatures called martial artists, that was hardly surprising.

Murim was full of show-offs who shouted the names of their forms even while fighting for their lives. You expected them to play dead?

Roll on the ground in that world, and people would humiliate you by claiming you had achieved Great Completion in Narye tagon.[3107] Naturally, the people willing to learn the Turtle Breath Technique were few.

Members of the unorthodox faction.

Wandering martial artists.

And…

[3106] Three hundred meters is about 980 feet.

[3107] Narye tagon is a martial-arts expression comparing an evasive roll to a lazy donkey rolling on the ground.

Assassins.

Unlike those first two groups, assassins were so rare you could go your whole life without seeing one.

An assassin could brush right past you without your realizing what they were. And if you *did* realize the person in front of you was an assassin, you were already pretty damn screwed.

Still, meeting one could sometimes be useful.

Especially when that assassin was known as the Slaughter Saint.

"I'm not sure what to teach you. But I can't exactly teach the Fire King's successor something like the Turtle Breath Technique…"

"Wow, the Turtle Breath Technique!"

"…?"

"Teach me! I want to live!"

"…Aren't you from the orthodox faction?"

"Do orthodox martial artists not die even when they get stabbed?"

"No, but you should be developing your martial arts—"

"Turtle Breath Technique! Turtle Breath Technique! Survival! Taekyung Grylls!"[3108]

"All right, just calm down. And stop spouting that strange nonsense."

In short, I was lucky.

The living legend of the assassin world had teaching skills that could put even Daechi-dong's top cram-school instructor to shame, and I was good at anything that involved using my body, so I absorbed his teachings like a sponge.

I had never dreamed I would use the Turtle Breath Technique in the modern world before using it in Murim. But it certainly worked.

Crunch!

A spear wreathed in blue-white flames was sucked into the dark monster's maw.

No—it shattered the teeth that had already grown back and buried itself in the roof of its mouth.

"GRAAAAAAAH!"

Crack-crack-crack!

The monster thrashed with a roar, crushing the little motorboat like a dried stalk.

I grabbed the wide-eyed Skeleton King by the back of his neck, kicked off the boat as it began to sink, and shot upward.

Boom!

Fragments burst behind me and grazed my shoulder. A fierce wind whipped over me.

[3108] "Taekyung Grylls" alludes to Bear Grylls, a television presenter known for survival programs.

I stepped onto an invisible staircase and stopped in midair.

Grrrrr.

Ragged breathing. The pupils of Leviathan's huge, crocodile-like eyes narrowed into long vertical slits.

"You. How could you…"

"Ah, that? It's a long story."

I grinned.

"And I'm not telling you."

Inventory open. Summon.

Along with the thought that accompanied the words, I hurled the spear in my hand.

Whoooooom!

Chapter 754

Whooooooosh!

Intense heat scorched the air and evaporated the moisture in its path.

A single streak of flame fell like a meteor. Leviathan's eyes widened as it twisted its body, forgetting even the pain that had come before.

Shhk!

Hot.

The spearhead sliced through scales that could shrug off missiles. A mere graze carved dozens of kilograms[3109] of flesh from its body.

No—it burned the flesh away.

Hissssss!

Leviathan screamed without a sound as searing pain swept through it.

From the day it first opened its eyes, the mythical monster had reigned as a calamity of the sea. Pain from fire was still foreign to it.

So was the human coming at it as fast as a beam of light.

Shh-shh-shh-shhk!

Leviathan had no idea when or how the spears had been launched.

It only heard the sharp whistle of something tearing through the air and saw five streaks of flame flying toward it. A red warning light flashed in its mind.

Danger!

Its massive body, rigid with pain, twisted desperately. Leviathan narrowly avoided the flame-wreathed spears and summoned its magical power.

Ruuumble!

A tremendous force pressed down from every direction.

Its wounds had not healed, but the quality and quantity of its magical power were far beyond what they had been a day ago.

A wave surged upward, brimming with magical power. At Leviathan's will, it advanced without a breath of wind to drive it.

Toward the human who had dared challenge the ruler of the sea.

And toward the traitor who wore the skin of a worthless human and attacked its own kind.

Whooooooosh!

A vast shadow covered a radius of several hundred meters.[3110] Magical power churned inside the pitch-black wave, where not even the faintest light could penetrate.

[3109] Dozens of kilograms is roughly 45–200 lb, depending on the amount.

[3110] Several hundred meters is roughly 1,000–3,000 ft.

“Damn it, I told you I don’t taste good…”

The Skeleton King muttered blankly.

At that very moment—

“Get lost.”

The low words came through clenched teeth. At the same moment, the human—Jin Taekyung—thrust out a fist wreathed in flame.

Boom!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Blue-white flames burst through the air and tore open the center of the wave.

A small human figure shot through the collapsing spray. Leviathan roared in fury.

“You bastard!”

Whooooooosh!

Streams of water surged up from every direction and shot toward Jin Taekyung’s entire body.

Each carried enough force to pierce an aircraft carrier. An ordinary human wouldn’t stand a chance.

If his opponent were an ordinary human.

Shhk.

The air vanished. The wind split apart.

Flames bloomed at the tip of a silver spearhead, unmistakably different from the ones Jin had hurled at Leviathan earlier.

Fwoosh. Shhk!

A blue line swept across the black sea.

The blue-white flame flowed like a dragon’s tail, burning away the jets of water that came at him like awls.

Jin Taekyung stepped on empty air again and accelerated. In the slowed world around him, he steadied his breathing.

My body…

It wasn’t like usual.

His hands and feet felt heavy. He wasn’t as fast as he used to be, and he was burning through internal energy much faster than he had expected.

That damn debuff.

Broken Body was taking an enormous toll in combat.

It might have been different if he had never possessed those capabilities in the first place. But with every attribute except Intelligence drastically reduced, the resulting void left his body unable to properly carry out the commands from his mind.

Just like now.

Thud!

The dull impact sent his body swaying. Jin swallowed his groan and evaded the attack that came immediately after.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Hundreds of spheres of water rushed at him, filling his vision.

They looked like the attack spell mages called Water Ball. Jin knew better than anyone that they were far more powerful.

He also knew that if he backed off now, he might lose the monster in front of him again.

Whoooom.

The nearly translucent white shaft of his spear trembled. Flames that had seemed about to die surged up fiercely.

Jin Taekyung drew the divine weapon far back and slashed down at an angle.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, second form.

Heavenly Strike.

Fwooooooosh!

A dazzling flash lit the darkness that had swallowed the surrounding sea.

Hellfire fell, evaporating the spheres of water on every side. Its glow stained the monster's enormous eye red.

"How dare you! How dare a mere human…!"

With a cry that was almost a scream, Leviathan drew up all its magical power.

Ruuuuumble.

The sea heaved, and the dark clouds overhead groaned.

The moment the spearhead met the barrier of magical power shielding Leviathan's body, a brilliant flash split the blackened sky.

It struck toward the human who had dared defy a myth.

Fwoosh!

In the slowed world, dozens of lightning bolts plunged from high above.

They emerged as dozens, but by the time they reached their destination, they had merged into one. That destructive force of nature was sucked toward a single point as though drawn there by something.

Crackle, crackle, crackle!

"Gyaaaaaaaah!"

Countless flashes lit the sea, accompanied by a scream of terrible pain.

Leviathan, holding the spearhead at bay with all its magical power, felt a surge of joy.

I knew it!

The voltage was in the billions of volts. No matter how strong the human was, he couldn't take a direct hit from that column of lightning and remain unharmed—

What?

Leviathan blinked its enormous eye.

Beyond the slowly fading flash, the human who should have been standing there with his flesh burned and his bones shattered by the lightning was staring back at Leviathan completely unharmed.

He even spoke, looking a little embarrassed.

"Uh, he's always been a scaredy-cat."

"…?"

"Hey, cut it out. That won't kill you."

What?

Leviathan tilted its head without realizing it. Beyond Jin Taekyung's shoulder, someone was letting out a terrible scream. Leviathan could see him clearly.

"Gyaaaaaaaah…"

The scream gradually faded.

The Skeleton King glanced down at his smoking body, then awkwardly lowered the sword in his hand.

"Ah, right. I'm a skeleton."

"Great timing. Good lightning-rod strategy."

"I only drew this to help you… No, as expected, you saw through my strategy perfectly. Not bad."

"…!"

What the hell were these bastards?

For a moment, Leviathan couldn't make sense of any of it.

That instant of distraction was enough to disrupt the flow of magical power that had been as solid as a wall with no gaps.

Crack!

The fissure was tiny compared to the whole barrier.

But it was exactly the opening Jin Taekyung had been desperately waiting for, and the flame dwelling in the spearhead smashed through the wavering magical power and plunged toward its target.

Thrust!

Scales shattered beneath the spearhead. Leviathan thrashed on instinct as its flesh and bone caught fire.

"GRAAAAAAAH!"

Rumble! Whooooooosh!

Its enormous body bucked wildly.

Jin Taekyung wasn't satisfied. He grabbed the small horns jutting from the monster's skin and drove more strength into the spear gripped in his hand.

Shhhhuuuk!

The spear's two-meter[3111] shaft plunged into the center of Leviathan's brow.

Its enormous head saved it from death, but the pain was beyond anything the mythical monster had ever suffered or imagined. It let out a terrible roar.

"You bastard!"

Whooooooosh!

Terrifyingly powerful Fear spread outward from Leviathan.

Marine creatures crouching in the deep sea rolled their eyes back and floated upward, while countless birds fleeing far away after sensing the danger that was about to arrive suddenly fell from the sky.

At this moment, Leviathan was angrier than it had ever been.

I'll kill them. I must!

It would tear them apart until no one could recognize them. The human who had inflicted this pain and the traitor who had turned on its own kind would die the most gruesome deaths it could give them.

But amid the pain and fury that consumed Leviathan, fear raised its head.

How?

The enemies had not only inflicted such a massive wound upon it the day before—they had deceived its senses and lured it into a trap.

Especially the human. That tiny creature had driven a weapon into its head and wielded a power Leviathan couldn't begin to understand.

He's strong. Stronger than any human I've ever seen.

During the Great Cataclysm, such a thing would have been unimaginable.

Leviathan had roamed the five oceans and sent countless lives to watery graves. Even the humans considered the strongest had failed each time they tried to hunt it.

Leviathan had always been the one doing the hunting.

It had been born a ruler and lived as a predator. In the vast sea, humans had always been prey—not even enough for a mouthful.

Looking back over its long life, Leviathan could think of only one being who had ever forced it to submit.

The master to whom it had sworn loyalty.

The Demon King Asmodeus.

"…!"

In that instant, Leviathan's eyes, stained with pain and anger, opened wide.

[3111] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.

Could this bastard be…?

It had heard of a human who had stood against its mighty master.

Leviathan had never met that human, but he had proved his strength by defeating countless monsters. The last had been the Demon King Asmodeus.

Then could this human really be…?

It had to be. There couldn't be two humans this strong.

Leviathan's mistaken conclusion swelled into terror. Its anger vanished, leaving only one thought.

I have to run. As far away as possible. I have to get away from him!

Anger? Fighting spirit?

None of that mattered. If this human had defeated the Demon King Asmodeus, whom Leviathan had served as its master, then its own fate was practically decided.

"GROOOOOOAR!"

Leviathan roared and shook its body.

It thrashed harder than ever, no longer from pain but in a struggle to survive. Yet it did nothing to dislodge the man already settled on its enormous body.

"Shut up. Shut up. Will you shut up?"

Bam! Bam! Bam!

Blood sprayed and flesh crumpled. Jin's tremendous grip tore out scales as tough as they came, pulling them free like cabbages. Flames around his fists crushed flesh and bone.

Thud. Crack!

"Kuhk. Khk."

The relentless pain nearly made Leviathan black out.

No human should have possessed such strength. In the end, only one way out remained.

The deep sea.

The place where Leviathan had first opened its eyes. An unknown domain deep beneath the ocean that no enemy had ever been able to invade.

If it reached that place, even this tenacious and terrifying human would be shaken off.

Whoosh!

Spray burst upward. Leviathan left the shallows for the open sea and dove deep.

Then it saw the human smiling and realized it had been wrong.

"Now we can finally fight together."

What?

The question flashed through Leviathan's mind.

And then—

Whooooooosh!

Deep in the dark water below, countless things gathered into one and blocked its path.

Bones.

They were bones.

Chapter 755

The Skeleton King was like a demonic sword.

A blade sharp enough to cut through anything, with killing power to match—yet one that had to remain sheathed.

A demonic sword that had to be drawn and wielded only when absolutely necessary, and only where no one was watching.

In that sense, the deep sea, swallowed by darkness on every side, was the perfect place.

Shwooooooosh!

A wave of bones surged and churned through the water.

The remains of sea creatures that had accumulated over hundreds, perhaps thousands, of years awoke at a single being's call.

The moment they opened their eyes, countless bones raced toward one another, obeying commands that bound their souls like chains.

Crack. Clatter-clatter!

They joined, gathered, and at last took shape: a massive gateway of bones blocking the entrance to the deep sea. A sturdy shield of wraiths that would let nothing living pass.

At the center of it all stood the king who had roused the wraiths sleeping deep beneath the seabed.

—Stop.

Fwooooooosh.

A tremendous force swelled.

Brilliant blond hair swayed with the current. Above his bare forehead, a faint silver light appeared and took shape.

A crown.

It was the mark of one who had claimed a throne for himself, and the power shining from it was far too brilliant to be called mere magical power.

—This is a royal command.

His voice held authority; his gaze, arrogance.

As those shining golden eyes fixed on Leviathan, it realized the true identity of the traitor who had dared turn against his own kind.

The Skeleton King…!

The king of wraiths.

One of the lords of the seventy-two legions sworn to the Demon King Asmodeus. He had led an immortal legion that rose again and again to fight humanity, until he himself met Erasure.

But the crowned traitor blocking Leviathan's path was not the Skeleton King it remembered.

How?

Where there was Erasure, there could also be birth. Someone else taking a vacant throne was only natural.

But this new king of wraiths was different. Far too different.

—How can you possess so much magical power and still side with mere humans?!

Leviathan's cry rang with bewilderment and rage. Its enormous body, hundreds of meters[3112] across, shot forward like a beam of light.

Kwaaaaaa!

Violent whirlpools spun in every direction.

Leviathan rushed toward the wall of white bones without a moment's hesitation.

No—it had no other choice.

It had to break through. If it could pass that wall and reach deeper water, it would survive.

Leviathan had first opened its eyes in the deep sea. In those pitch-black depths, where no one could intrude, it was certain it could win.

At least, that was what it believed until a quiet voice came with a fresh stab of agony.

"Where are you off to in such a hurry? We haven't even settled the bill yet."

Crunch!

—GRAAAAAAAH!

Leviathan's massive body, which had been shooting forward like a ray of light, writhed violently.

Jin Taekyung gripped the spear shaft buried deep in the monster's brow with one hand. With the other, he drove a sword—drawn from who knew where—into its enormous eye.

He spoke almost in a whisper.

"At one hit per person, we'd be here for three days and four nights. Let's round it off at a thousand."

Less than a day had passed, and the confirmed casualties already exceeded a hundred thousand.

They were strangers whose faces and names Jin did not know, but as he stared into the writhing Leviathan's eyes, his own gaze burned with cold fury.

"We have to collect the blood debt, don't we?"

Monsters and humans. Humans and monsters.

[3112] Several hundred meters is roughly 660–3,000 ft for a range of 200–900 m.

Their fate had been set the moment the Demon King Asmodeus first stepped onto this land more than thirty years ago.

Jin, once a boy whose father had gone away one day and never returned, remembered him clearly. He knew the pain of those this disaster had left in the same position.

Inventory open. Summon.

Spears, swords, axes.

It didn't matter.

Countless weapons he had shoved deep into his Inventory whenever he had the chance flashed into his hands one after another, then plunged toward their targets in the blink of an eye.

Thrust-thrust-thrust! Crunch!

Scales shattered. Bone and flesh crumpled.

The precise circulation of internal energy he usually employed was nowhere to be seen, but even that was enough.

The mythical monster that had reigned as a calamity of the sea all its life writhed in agony unlike anything it had ever known.

—GRAAAAAAAH!

Ruuuuumble!

Magical power erupted from Leviathan, shaking the sea.

Marine creatures swept in by the waves succumbed to its overwhelming Fear. Their eyes rolled back—and then a quiet voice breathed new souls into their dead bodies.

—Rise.

The fin of a blue whale that had been slowly sinking twitched. Dozens of sturgeon, torn apart for the monster's meal only hours earlier, bared their sawlike teeth.

—Grrrrrrr.

—Grk. Grk.

Dead, yet not dead.

The countless marine creatures that had finally become a single legion moved as one body. And at their head stood the king of wraiths who had awakened them.

—My legion!

Craaaaaack!

At the Skeleton King's cry, the wall of bones collapsed.

No. It became a single enormous monster of bones and charged at Leviathan.

Kwaaaaaa!

Through a haze of green blood, Leviathan saw the Skeleton Legion rushing at it as one and roared.

—How dare you, you worthless things!

Gooooong. Boom!

Compressed seawater fired through the depths like cannonballs. Hundreds of blasts smashed countless bones apart.

But even Leviathan, calamity of the sea, could not control everything.

This vast ocean belonged entirely to it, but the countless deaths and wraiths flowing within the waves followed only the owner of the crown.

—Open your eyes.

Magical power surged around the Skeleton King. Amid the churning currents, wraiths on the verge of Erasure raised their heads.

—Raise Skeleton.

Clatter-clatter-clatter!

Leviathan opened wide the eye Jin Taekyung had half-crushed.

—…!

Bones scattered by the blasts gathered again. Broken pieces reassembled into new shapes and clung to Leviathan's enormous body.

They seeped through the cracks in its strength and clung to the monster's magical power, which still had not run dry, draining it like leeches.

Shhhhhhh!

What the hell…?

Leviathan was stunned. Even the Skeleton King of the past could not have rebuilt his legion so quickly and easily.

Where had this wealth of magical power come from? How could he command his legion to attack Leviathan, a monster plainly above them?

And there was something else.

My magical power has no effect on him.

Among monsters, power governed everything.

Yet this Skeleton King—the traitor newly seated on the throne of wraiths—was different. He might fear Leviathan, but its magical power did not control him. If anything, the deeper they went, the more freely he fought.

How?

Had Leviathan fully regained its former strength, or simply kept its composure, it might have understood.

The Skeleton King's power was different in nature from ordinary magical power. And after defeating the Arch Lich and Behemoth, both named S-rank monsters, and absorbing so much magical power, his standing was not far below Leviathan's.

But Leviathan had awoken from its long sleep only days ago. Now it was gravely wounded and exhausted. Everything happening around it seemed impossibly confusing.

Confusing enough to make it forget reality for one brief moment.

Then a terrible burning pain jolted it back to its senses.

Fwoosh. Sizzle-sizzle!

Leviathan clenched what remained of its teeth. Half were already gone.

It had fought countless humans called Hunters during the Great Cataclysm, but it had never felt pain like this. Blades wreathed in aura had barely stung, and even its worst injuries had soon healed after it absorbed another monster's magical power and rested.

But the flames tearing through its enormous head even now, turning flesh and bone to ash, were different.

That tiny human was different.

"Fifty. Fifty-one. Fifty-two. Fifty-three…"

Thrust-thrust-thrust!

He was nothing like the humans Leviathan had fought before. He was on another level.

He kept muttering without pause as he drove weapons of unknown origin into various parts of Leviathan's body and twisted them around. There was even a madness in his muttering that not even monsters could approach.

"We're halfway there already. Come on, let's keep it up a little longer."

"Sir, just one more set."

"Hold still. You'll break a bone."

"Of course, it'll break even if you don't. Go ahead and fuck around if you want to die in even more pain."

—GRAAAAAAAAAH!

Leviathan let out a horrible cry.

It was no roar. It was a scream.

The Fear that had once made the shores beyond the five oceans tremble had become fear in the plainest sense, binding Leviathan itself.

All because of one human, impossibly small beside it.

Die? I'm going to die? Me?

An instinct for survival, forgotten over a lifetime as a predator, awoke.

One eye was so badly mangled that Leviathan could no longer make out its surroundings. Its body drew closer to death by the moment.

As its pain slowly dulled, Leviathan assessed its situation.

One chance. I need one opening to shake them off and flee as far as I can.

There was still hope.

Its tenacious vitality. The half of its magical power it had yet to spend. And its enemies were no longer as they had been when it first met them.

Especially that human who had dealt it such devastating damage with a single attack the day before.

If he could use that power again, I'd already be dead. Something must have happened to him.

Leviathan was a highly intelligent monster. Its assessment was shrewd, and it made its life-or-death decision at once.

—Kwoooooo!

Its massive body, hundreds of meters[3113] in diameter, writhed with all its strength and released its magical power. A tremendous force surged outward like something inflating, pushing away everything around it.

Kwaaaaaa!

Dozens of whirlpools formed under the tremendous water pressure.

Leviathan shook off the Skeletons draining its magical power like leeches and charged in one direction.

Whooooooosh!

The water flowing over its enormous body became violent whirlpools and churned wildly.

The Skeleton King missed it by a hair and shouted, his voice close to a scream.

—Human! Get out of the way!

Too late.

Leviathan kept that thought to itself and drove forward with all its strength—toward a cliff rooted deep in the seabed for thousands of years.

It would scrape that wretched human off.

And then—

Ruuuuumble!

The collision sent a tremendous shock through the sea.

I tried to get out of the way. I could have made it.

I'd just forgotten one important thing in the heat of battle.

Some of my powers had an expiration date.

Beep.

[3113] Several hundred meters is roughly 660–3,000 ft for a range of 200–900 m.

SYSTEM

The duration of the Water Rescue Worker Title has ended!
The effects of the Water Rescue Worker Title have disappeared!
The Water Rescue Worker's Webbing has disappeared!
The Water Rescue Worker's Gills have disappeared!
Reactivation will be possible in 6 days 23 hours 59 seconds!

Damn it.

Before I could even spit out that single curse, a massive boulder covered in green moss and seaweed had come up right behind me.

Crack!

"Guh!"

A powerful impact. Then pain squeezed my entire body.

Through the momentarily whitened field of vision, I saw Leviathan's back as it staggered toward the surface, fleeing despite being unable to fully absorb the force of the collision.

I also saw the Skeleton King chasing after it while riding a half-dismembered shark.

Clatter-clatter-clatter!

Bone Binding.

A net of bones shot across the current and blocked the enormous body, but it could not restrain the monster thrashing with a desperate will to survive.

Crunch!

The bones shattered and scattered in every direction.

But it wasn't over.

I fought the water pressure bearing down on me and tightened my grip on the spear shaft.

Craaaaack.

Cold, dark seawater crept toward my mouth and nose. That was fine.

My sharpened senses were still fixed on the target. So was the blue-white hellfire gathered along the transparent spearhead. So were my muscles, every fiber drawn taut toward the enormous monster fleeing in the distance.

Shhhhhhh.

Every nerve in my body came alive.

It was the same situation as yesterday. But this time would be different. I knew it with my whole body.

There won’t be a second time.

Trusting myself, intent on killing it, I hurled the spear with all my strength.

Shhwaaaak!

A single streak of flame crossed the sea. At its end came the scream I had been waiting for.

—GRAAAAAAAAAH!

The hunt was over.

Chapter 756

The desire to live isn't granted to humans alone.

Any creature that can breathe and think will struggle until its final breath. All the more so a born predator that has never once imagined its own death.

Shwoosh! Splurch!

"GRAAAAAAAAAH!"

A spear shot in from behind and burrowed into Leviathan's lava-like bulk.

Its vision flashed white. Screaming in pain, Leviathan clenched its broken teeth.

I won't die. This body won't die. Never!

It swam with all its might.

But for all the ferocity of its will to survive, its fins and tail—once swift enough to cut through the vast ocean like rays of light—barely moved. Its whole body, once brimming with strength, was growing heavier.

Why the hell…?

Leviathan gasped for breath. It couldn't stop now.

It had finally managed to shake them off. The way to survival was open. All it had to do was flee as far as it could and hide.

Whether it took decades or centuries, it could have its revenge someday—so long as it survived today. Unlike humans, fated to die after barely a hundred years, Leviathan could live for something close to eternity as long as it had water and magical power.

In the end, I'm the one who will survive. Not you bastards. This Leviathan!

It forced up the body that kept trying to sink. Riding the waves left by the battle, carried by the current, it headed for the refuge waiting somewhere far away.

Or so it believed, until something cold and hard blocked its path.

Boom.

A dull impact sent a jolt back through its body.

A reef?

Leviathan raised its head. In its half-crushed eye, it saw a steel ship gleaming in the sunlight—and a human standing above it, looking down.

"Operation complete. We'll capture the target now."

The quiet voice reached Leviathan's ears. It couldn't tell whom the human was addressing, and it couldn't understand the words. Their meaning was easy enough to guess.

"…Not yet. Not yet."

Leviathan gathered every last scrap of strength. It raised the tail that had once smashed dozens of aircraft carriers apart in a single blow and lashed out at him.

Then—

Splash.

Water scattered feebly where its tail, once dozens of meters[3114] long, should have been.

Only then did the monster of myth understand. Its magnificent tail was gone. The streak of flame fired from behind had melted away half its body.

"Ah."

Leviathan groaned.

Choi Minwoo, the human who had crushed its last hope, watched two figures approaching in the distance and smiled faintly.

"Thank you for your hard work."

"Waaaaaaaaah!"

"Uhyooooo! Leviathan getto da ze![3115]"

At Team Leader Choi's words, the sailors of the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force aboard the aircraft carrier let out a tremendous cheer.

I had vomited up enough seawater to fill a kettle before barely managing to open my mouth.

"Tell them to keep it down. My head's ringing."

The Skeleton King, so drenched he looked pickled in seawater, chimed in.

"Tell them to stop making a fuss now that it's over and just steer the ship. If they keep this up, I'll summon the vengeful spirits of Pearl Harbor.[3116] You know what happens then, don't you?"

Team Leader Choi nodded.

"Yes. We'd run another raid right here."

"…Are you serious?"

"I'm joking."

I left the wounded-looking Skeleton King behind and headed to the rear of the aircraft carrier.

The enormous monster lay bound tight in a magic-infused net, struggling to breathe.

"You…"

Even with its crushed eye, it somehow recognized me and muttered like a groan. I brushed back my wet hair and waved.

"Yeah, it's me, you son of a bitch."

[3114] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 65–300 ft.

[3115] *Getto da ze* is a colloquial Japanese exclamation meaning "Got it!"

[3116] Pearl Harbor is the US naval base in Hawaii attacked by Japan in 1941.

"K-kill me. I have not the slightest intention of suffering humiliation at the hands of a mere human."

I blinked silently. Then I asked Team Leader Choi,

"Did anyone say we were keeping this thing alive?"

"Certainly not me."

"Not me either. You?"

The Skeleton King had followed me over. He answered flatly.

"Are you insane?"

"Right? I was wondering what the hell that bullshit was about."

I shrugged and drove White Flame, which I'd recovered on the way here, into Leviathan's body.

Splurch!

A faint groan escaped it. It seemed as if death, which had drawn close once again, flickered in Leviathan's eyes.

Half its body was already gone. Tenacious as it was, there was no coming back from a wound like that.

But first, I needed an answer.

"You should've stayed asleep. What made you crawl all the way out here?"

"…Kill me."

"Oh, you don't need to worry about that."

Splurch! Crack.

I slowly twisted the spearhead embedded in its torso. Leviathan convulsed as the blade ground against its bones, then answered in a rush.

"F-food! I smelled food!"

"An S-rank Magic Gem."

I'd expected as much. Still twisting the spearhead, I asked my next question.

"Who woke you up?"

"Woke me up?"

"We wouldn't know. You would."

I tightened my grip on the spear shaft. Its answer came through a groan, but it didn't change.

"Ghk. Ghk. I-I don't know. I'd been starving for so long, and then I sensed magical power coming from the sea. That's all."

Was it telling the truth?

I didn't have to think long. Everyone got honest when death was staring them in the face, and I couldn't see the slightest trace of a lie in Leviathan. It had already lost the will to live.

Damn it.

I swallowed my disappointment.

It was obvious who had lured it here with an unrefined S-rank Magic Gem.

Michael Silbert.

The problem was proving it. Without evidence that he'd caused this disaster, no one would believe me.

That was how much standing Odin Guild—and Michael Silbert—had in the world. He was more than a hero of the Great Cataclysm. He was in a position to reach for the place only one person in human history had ever occupied.

Normally, it would be impossible even if I died and came back to life… But things are different now.

Cheon Taemin.

If Prometheus had given humanity fire, Cheon Taemin had defeated the Demon King Asmodeus and given humanity peace. He'd done it not in some myth embroidered with fiction, but in the real world, only a few decades ago. No one had done anything like it before or since.

Yet he, too, had become part of the past.

To people living in the present, Cheon Taemin was great but impossibly distant. They were still grateful to him, yet they resented him more than anyone.

The world now cheered for a hero who acted before everyone's eyes, not one who had withdrawn from it.

For Michael Silbert—one of the countless people who had lived in Cheon Taemin's shadow.

…Damn it.

The strength drained out of me. I pulled the spear shaft from deep inside Leviathan's body and aimed it at its neck.

The hunt was over. It was time to put this damn monster down.

"Goodbye. Try not to find peace in the next life."

I raised the spear. Blue-white flames already burned along its transparent blade.

One Strike.

That was all it would take. With its strength completely spent, Leviathan's body would split like tofu beneath the Force.

I didn't hesitate.

Whoom.

The flames burned through the wind as the spear fell.

Leviathan stared blankly up at it. Then it spoke.

The time has come.

What?

I twisted the spearhead as the question flashed through my mind. But fatigue lay on me as heavy as the salt in the seawater, and my body reacted half a beat too late.

Shhk! Shwaaaaaak!

The thick neck, several meters[3117] across, was sliced in half.

Beyond the green blood surging up like a wave, my eyes met the monster's eyes, already overshadowed by irreversible death.

Its final thought sounded in my mind, not my ears.

Magical power stirred my hunger. But it was you humans—and this world—that woke me from my deep sleep.

"…!"

The time has come, human. Please survive. Survive to the very end. Survive until the end of this world, and see with your own eyes the day I never got to see…

Splash.

The thought faded, then ended like an echo. At the same time, the enormous maw that had been trembling violently slammed into the surface of the water.

And as I stared at the light fading from its eyes, confused, a clear ringing filled my ears.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 170 Leviathan!
You have successfully completed Quest: Calamity of the Sea!
You have acquired a massive amount of EXP and Fame!
Level Up!
Special Debuff: Broken Body rejects the power of healing!
Leviathan is a powerful S-rank monster and the only Named Monster. Since you have accumulated remarkable achievements, an additional Reward will be granted!
The effects of Title: Water Rescue Worker have been enhanced!
The name of Title: Water Rescue Worker will be changed!
You have acquired Title: Hope of the Sea!
…
…
…

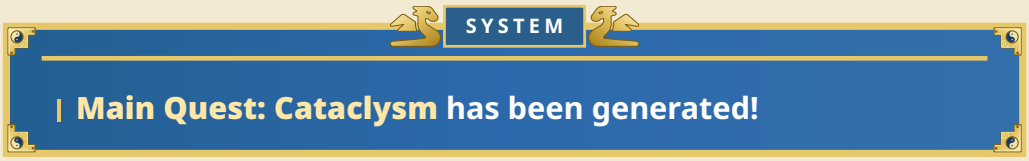
[3117] Several meters is roughly 3–9 m, or about 10–30 ft.

The bells rang without pause like a victory salute. I couldn't move. An inexplicable sense of foreboding had taken hold of me.

The time has come.

Leviathan's final words ran through my mind again, and suddenly I understood.

Ding.



A change too vast to measure was already drawing close to this world.

Leviathan was dead.

The news was brief but electrifying. It reached Japan's Ministry of Defense first, then spread across Japan and out into the world.

[Jin Taekyung succeeds in Leviathan raid!]

[The Calamity of the Sea finally meets its death!]

[The miracle of twenty-four hours. Asia's star takes flight after falling to rock bottom!]

People who had held back their fear and prayed desperately for the raid's success erupted in cheers. News outlets around the world, which had watched Japan with bated breath, poured out articles as though they'd been waiting for their cue.

[The dazzling rise of a young hero.]

[Japanese Prime Minister boldly declares at a press conference, defying everyone's expectations: "I kept it. Because it was a promise."]

[Japanese Defense Minister abruptly dismissed. Senior Ministry of Defense official laments: "The Defense Minister was considering a kamikaze[3118] operation."]

[A great achievement accomplished by only two S-rank Hunters!]

[Japanese netizens condemn the government and praise the hero. "What on earth was Japan's S-rank Hunter Yamamoto doing?" "Let's make Jin Taekyung our shogun![3119]"]

[Korean netizens mock Japan: "Yamamoto must have been cleaning."]

Countless articles and news reports swept across the internet like waves. At the center of them all was one name.

Jin Taekyung.

[3118] *Kamikaze* refers to Japanese suicide attacks during World War II.

[3119] A *shogun* was a military ruler of Japan.

Asia’s star.
A bird that had taken flight once more after an endless fall.
But amid the praise and cheers of the entire world, he couldn’t smile.

Chapter 757

Twenty-eight hours.

That was all the time we spent in Japan.

If we'd answered every request for an interview or press conference, twenty-eight days wouldn't have been enough.

At first, I hadn't planned to stand in front of the cameras at all. Then Team Leader Choi said something that changed my mind.

"The survivors need courage and hope."

Prime Minister Koizumi welcomed my decision with open arms. He'd been such an attention seeker since his youth that people had treated him like a madman.

When I entered the press conference hall, I was greeted by cheers and a barrage of camera flashes.

"Waaaaaaaah!"

Pop-pop-pop-pop!

It was strange. Less than a month had passed since all this began, yet it felt like ages since I'd last stood before reporters of my own free will. Ages since the media had looked on me favorably, too.

That didn't mean I wanted to waste time. I still had a problem I couldn't tell anyone about, and somewhere in the world, another fire was probably breaking out even now.

"Let's make this quick."

But the Japanese press made up more than half the room, and they weren't easy to handle. In more ways than one.

"Jin-sama[3120]! Please become Japan's shogun[3121]! You're the only one who can save these islands!"

I answered the first reporter's question—or rather, his shout.

"Get him out."

The Self-Defense Forces personnel guarding the hall took him by both arms. As they dragged him away, the microphone dropped from his hand. Another Japanese reporter snatched it up.

"Leviathan was so feared by the people of Japan that we called it Susanoo. Yet Jin Taekyung-sama[3122] defeated it without much difficulty."

What the hell is he talking about? It was fucking hard.

But I didn't let it show and answered calmly.

[3120] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

[3121] A *shogun* was a hereditary military ruler of Japan.

[3122] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

“It wasn’t an easy fight, but I did my best while thinking of those who lost their lives to Leviathan.”

“Ah…!”

“I’d also like to offer my heartfelt condolences to their families.”

I bowed my head. Tears glimmered in many of the reporters’ eyes. The Japanese reporter wiped his eyes with his sleeve before continuing.

“Thank you for saying that.”

“I only did what had to be done.”

“I’m sorry, but may I ask one more question?”

Normally, no. The rule was one question per reporter, and I had no intention of letting this drag on. But he’d asked a good question, so I nodded.

“Go ahead.”

“Do you know Amaterasu, the sun goddess?”

“What? Which terrace?”

“I’m asking seriously. Jin Taekyung-sama[3123], who defeated Susanoo—are you perhaps the reincarnation of Amaterasu, the sun goddess?”

“No, for fuck’s sake…”

The Self-Defense Forces waiting nearby rushed in, covered the reporter’s mouth, and snatched away his microphone.

Not that the remaining Japanese reporters asked normal questions.

“If you could name just three Japanese anime you like… Mmph!”

Patriotism was one thing, but these people were fucking nuts.

Once I realized how much time it took to restrain each reporter and drag them out, I decided to break through head-on.

“What have you generally thought of Japan?”

“An island. Next.”

“Japan has long been a nation that values peace and courtesy—”

“Wakō pirates, the Imjin War, the second Japanese invasion of Korea, the Japanese colonial period, World War II. Next.”[3124]

“Our S-rank Hunter Yamamoto Genji has expressed some personal regret. He claims the raid on Leviathan would have been far easier if you’d conducted a joint operation with him. What do you think?”

“Then he should’ve shown up on time. Next.”

“No, please wait a moment! Yamamoto-san[3125] had circumstances that prevented him from coming!”

[3123] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

[3124] The *wakō* were Japanese pirates who raided the coasts of Korea and China; the Imjin War and second Japanese invasion of Korea refer to Japan’s invasions of Korea in 1592 and 1597.

[3125] *-san* is a common Japanese honorific used as a polite form of address.

"A reporter… talking back?"

"…!"

I swept through the press conference like Zhao Zilong[3126] through an army of a hundred thousand.

Plenty of idiots asked questions that barely qualified as questions. But there were plenty of sharp ones, too—about the Skeleton King, for instance, rather than me.

They wanted to know how the raid had succeeded, what had happened to Leviathan's corpse after it vanished in the explosion, and where the two S-rank Magic Gems supplied by the Japanese government had gone.

I might have stumbled if Team Leader Choi hadn't seen those questions coming.

"Skel—no, Stone-King is an excellent Hunter who played a decisive role in this raid. Please understand that exhaustion prevented him from joining us today."

"The details of the raid are classified. I can't disclose them."

"Unfortunately, the corpse disappeared. The S-rank Magic Gem used as bait to lure Leviathan was also lost in the process. We offer our deepest apologies for this."

"Ah…"

"What a loss…"

A high-level monster's corpse was a treasure in its own right. Losing Leviathan's was bad enough; losing the Japanese government's S-rank Magic Gems drew sighs from the reporters.

Of course, if they found out it was all a lie, those sighs would turn to fury.

Team Leader Choi could take up acting.

I muttered as I watched him finish speaking without even twitching an eyebrow.

Leviathan's corpse? The Magic Gems?

Of course we'd taken them all. They were in the safest, most discreet place I knew: my Inventory.

The sudden explosion of magical power while Leviathan's corpse was being transferred to the aircraft carrier had been the Skeleton King's work. I'd used the opening to stuff everything into my Inventory. The Maritime Self-Defense Force sailors had watched it all vanish before their eyes and stood there in a daze.

I do feel a little bad…

But what else was I supposed to do? Leviathan's corpse was mine to begin with, and I'd just have to consider the Japanese government's S-rank Magic Gems a long-term loan.

Even the finest sword in the world becomes nothing more than a kitchen knife in a cook's hands. This was a time when I had to move like this, even if it meant selling my conscience.

[3126] Zhao Zilong was a general of China's Three Kingdoms period, celebrated in accounts of his charge through enemy forces.

…Cataclysm.

If I was going to solve that Quest—one question mark after another, weighing on my mind—I had to.

Even during the Great Cataclysm, Leviathan had been a monster of tremendous significance. Decades after the war's end, it still was.

Disasters large and small were unfolding across the world, yet its death drew every eye to Japan. It also etched the name of a young hero whose star had begun to fade into everyone's minds once more.

[Grand Mage Magic Johnson: "I'm a mage, but Jin is magic itself."]

[Prince Felix: "His nobility lies not in the blood flowing through his veins, but in his very being."]

[S-rank Hunter Faye Chen, speaking to reporters after suppressing a Monster Wave in downtown Hong Kong: "Free Hong Kong, Great Jin."]

[He has returned.]

[The star of Asia who never lost his light despite countless condemnations. No—the star of the world.]

[A life-or-death struggle at sea. Hope triumphs over calamity.]

[The world's worst terrorist twisted a hero's goodwill into evil. A public gripped by fear lost its judgment.]

[Head of North America's largest media association finally speaks amid mounting criticism: "We have always reported only the facts. The claim that we targeted Jin Taekyung is nothing more than a malicious rumor."]

The world's major news outlets were the first to change their stance.

Journalists who had remained neutral from the start, or had supported Jin Taekyung, paid Leviathan's death all the respect they could. Those who had already joined forces with Odin Guild couldn't change course so easily.

The fickle public had reversed its opinion overnight, and that was cause for caution. Michael Silbert, however, was more than a cause for caution. He was someone to fear.

But while those journalists fretted, the public was slowly waking from the media's incitement and its fear of terrorism.

"Simon. Why are you still in the office? Weren't you supposed to cover the anti–Jin Taekyung protest in the square today?"

"Uh, it was canceled."

"What?"

"Most of the participants dropped out. They were expecting thirty thousand, but once the number fell below five hundred, everyone dispersed."

“How does a protest that big fall apart so easily… Damn it. Fine. What about the organizer? The guy who acted like he was about to drop a bomb on Korea. Daniel, was it?”

“Oh, Daisuke?”

“Yeah, him. Tell him we’ll give him extensive coverage, so he needs to gather some people right away—”

The news director stopped badgering Simon and frowned.

“Wait. Who’s Daisuke? We’re talking about Daniel.”

“Yes. Daniel Daisuke. That’s the organizer’s full name.”

“…Don’t tell me.”

“I regret being the one to say it, Boss, but it’s exactly what you think.”

The reporter let out a put-upon sigh and explained everything to his superior point by point.

First, as the name Daisuke suggested, the protest organizer was of Japanese descent.

Second, Japanese and Koreans disliking one another was as natural as universal gravitation. That was why Daniel Daisuke had taken the lead in organizing the protest.

Third. Jin Taekyung had saved Japan, and Daniel Daisuke was a devoted son, and his mother was a Japanese woman from Tokyo.

“He’s the hero who saved his mother’s hometown. That’s basically what happened.”

It was a clean, no-frills explanation made entirely of facts. The news director, who had listened in silence, answered with one word.

“Fuck.”

His head throbbed. The protest’s cancellation wasn’t their fault, but would the “anonymous sponsor” who had promised a massive investment in return for a little biased coverage see it that way?

Damn it. Management’s going to raise hell.

As he sighed with a complicated expression, his eyes fell on the television screen playing silently in the background.

[**Breaking News: Magical-power readings surge in Berlin. Monster Wave likely.**]

[**German government issues a Class 2 disaster warning.**]

[**German Prime Minister Markus makes an emergency announcement. A formal request for assistance has been sent to Korea.**]

Another Monster Wave.

The news director shook his head, then turned to Simon, who was still watching him for a reaction.

“What are you waiting for? Why aren’t you rushing to Berlin right now?”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung. The German government has requested assistance.”

I answered Team Leader Choi without hesitation.

“I’ll go.”

The battle had left me exhausted, and the Broken Body debuff was still active. But this was what I had to do.

“I’ll get ready right away.”

And just as I rose from my seat, Team Leader Choi’s voice pierced my ears.

“At the same time… we also requested assistance from Michael Silbert.”

I slowly turned around.

Chapter 758

“At the same time… we also requested assistance from Michael Silbert.”

The name that Team Leader Choi suddenly blurted out.

Michael Silbert.

I paused, but I wasn’t particularly surprised. A drowning person would reach for any hand they could find.

The German government had sensed the disaster closing in and called for the two people most likely to save them.

Me and Michael Silbert.

“That gloomy, unpleasant human bastard?”

The Skeleton King looked uneasy.

“I’d rather not run into him.”

“No one here wants to.”

He clicked his tongue. “True, but something about him felt wrong from the moment I first saw him… Never mind. We need to get there before his lot.”

This wasn’t a sport where we competed to save the most lives, but I agreed with him on that.

If this keeps up, no one will be able to stop him.

The greatest beneficiary of these meticulously engineered disasters was Michael Silbert. Since the first terrorist attack, Odin Guild had suppressed more than ten Monster Waves around the world. Michael had killed S-rank monsters in most of those battles, earning acclaim for his extraordinary feats.

For a while, he had even made people forget Cheon Taemin’s name.

I have to stop him now, while there’s still time. Somehow.

I didn’t know what Michael Silbert ultimately wanted. But if a monster like him gained unchecked fame and power—if he became as untouchable as Cheon Taemin—I was certain a disaster worse than anything we’d seen would follow.

“Team Leader Choi.”

He understood what I meant and nodded. “The pilots are already waiting.”

Team Leader Choi, the Skeleton King, and I hurried toward the aircraft that had already been prepared, exchanging words as we went.

“What’s happening in Germany?”

“A Class 2 disaster warning has been issued, centered around Munich. According to the information provided by the German government, a Monster Wave will occur within five hours at the latest.”

“If five hours is the government’s upper limit…”

Team Leader Choi nodded. “It could happen at any moment.”

Running on wishful thinking in the face of disaster was a universal human trait. Or at least governments responsible for evacuating people had no choice but to do so.

The moment the German government officially admitted, “We’re fucked,” a major city like Munich would descend into chaos in an instant.

“Damn it.”

“Fortunately, their response so far has been excellent. Every country in the world has been on high alert since the terrorist attack on the Paris branch, and more than three thousand Hunters have gathered in Munich since the Class 2 disaster warning was issued. Our Ares Guild is one of them.”

“That’s something, at least. What about Odin? No—that man?” the Skeleton King asked.

“Of course, Hunters from the Odin Guild branch in Munich are standing by as well, but… the core forces led by Michael Silbert are currently in Africa.”

“Africa?”

“Yes. From what we’ve learned, they’re suppressing a Monster Wave in South Africa. They’ll head straight to Munich once they’re finished.”

“How nice for him. Starts trouble all over the place, then cleans it up one at a time?”

The Skeleton King sneered, but I shook my head.

“That’s not it.”

“Hm?”

“If it had been part of his calculations from the beginning, he would have left for Munich by now. So at least the incident in Munich wasn’t a terrorist attack he had a hand in.”

“Exactly,” Team Leader Choi said. “That makes it even more dangerous.”

“Why? If he didn’t intend for it to happen, wouldn’t that mean—”

The Skeleton King fell silent. His puzzled expression hardened.

“Ah.”

He’d realized it too. What this meant, and how much danger lay behind it.

Monster Waves can happen on their own now. No terrorist attack required.

They had still occurred after peace returned, of course. The problem was their frequency. A disaster that had once happened *very rarely* was becoming something that happened *sometimes*, perhaps even *often*.

Often enough to remind humanity of the days when corpses piled up like mountains and rivers ran with blood.

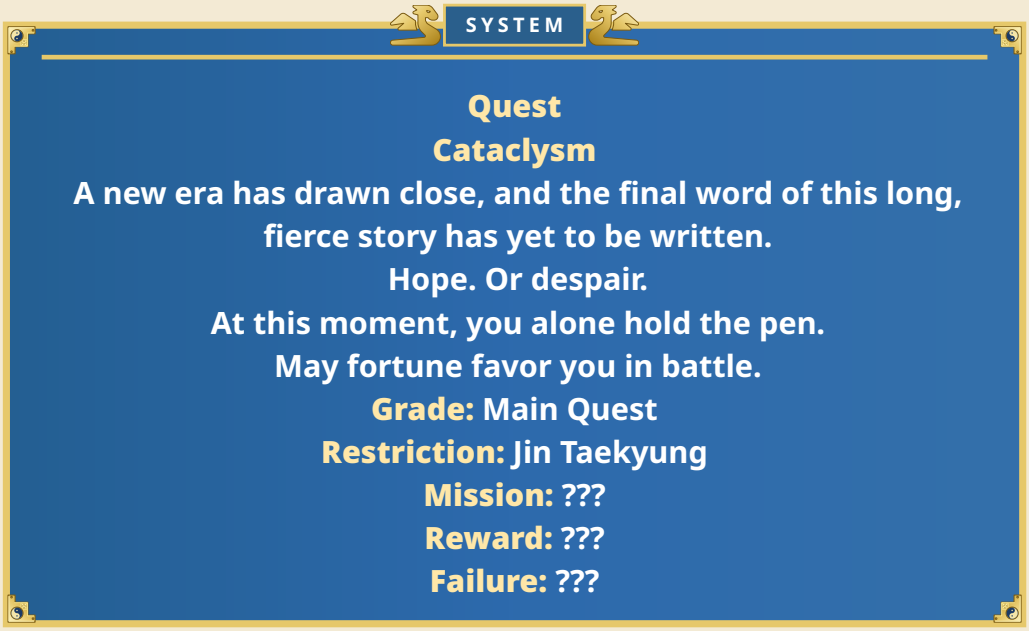
The Great Cataclysm.

Humanity had given that horrific past a name. But what would people call the new age of disaster that was about to begin—or perhaps already had?

And what was the System, which had brought me both happiness and pain, trying to tell me?

Open Quest Window.

Ding.



The quest description offered no clear answer, and its mission was nothing but question marks.

More than anything, though, one short line under **Grade** weighed on my chest. Those five characters burned into my eyes.

Main Quest.

I'd received more quests than I could count, from easy Third Rate quests to Supreme Peak ones that put my life on the line. Their grades varied with the difficulty, and there were different types, too, like sudden quests.

But a Main Quest was a first.

More precisely, this was the first since I'd opened my eyes in the unfamiliar world of Murim. Since the day it had all begun.

What the hell does this mean?

I didn't know what the mission was or what this approaching era would bring.

No. Deep down, I had an idea. I was trying hard to convince myself I was wrong.

Because I was afraid.

Just as the System had said, I was the only one holding the pen now.

The days when I could laugh over web novels full of satisfying victories were long gone. Now I had to write the story myself.

With a pen. With a spear.

With blood and death that might belong to anyone.

"...man. Human?"

A voice that had seemed far away pulled me out of my thoughts.

I blinked and looked around. Unfamiliar faces. Noise. A propeller spinning with a roar, and beyond the fighter jet's windows, the tense faces of the pilots.

Two people were watching me with concern.

No. One person and one monster.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, are you all right?"

"Wicked human. Look closely. How many fingers am I holding up?"

The Skeleton King was slowly waving a hand in front of my face.

"I don't see any."

"Wrong. One. Your condition is worse than I thought—"

"I deliberately didn't count the finger you're waving because I'm going to pull it out soon."

"…"

"You're still waving it. Fold that finger while I'm asking nicely."

As the Skeleton King quietly folded the middle finger he had been enthusiastically waving, Team Leader Choi spoke in a subdued voice.

"If something's wrong, we can wait until you've rested. We don't know what kind of S-rank monster will appear, but there are forces on-site capable of responding to it, so…"

"No. I'm fine."

I cut him off. Mental exhaustion and the Broken Body debuff had left me far from my best, but every moment we delayed would mean more damage. That much was obvious.

My mission now is to stop the disaster. The disaster in Munich—and, beyond that, the disaster that would swallow this world.

"Let's go. Before we lose any more time."

I climbed aboard the fighter jet, thinking of the man at the center of it all. The enemy I would soon face again.

Michael Silbert.

Come to Munich.

The words lingered on my tongue, then faded without ever reaching him.

South Africa.

Commonly known in Korea by the abbreviation Nam-agong, this country was Africa's most highly developed industrial nation. Because it had few Gates, it was also one of the countries that had suffered the least damage from monsters, from the Great Cataclysm until now.

At least until half a day ago.

Rumble!

Smoke and flames blotted out the clear sky.

Cape Town, the capital of South Africa, welcomed wealthy visitors and countless tourists from around the world. Now it was filled with screams, death, and the roars of monsters.

Crunch! Crash!

“Graaaah!”

“Ghk!”

A pack of Trolls took over the road, swinging their clubs at anything in reach. Their steel clubs struck with the immense strength of large monsters, cutting down people fleeing in every direction. Each fell with a final cry.

Crack!

“Kwoooaar!”

The leader stomped a fallen corpse’s head apart and let out a savage roar. Its followers, tasting human blood for the first time in ages, gave in to instinct.

Craaaack!

They seized a moving car and slammed it into the ground. Dozens rushed at buildings large and small, smashing them until they collapsed. Explosions erupted everywhere, but the Trolls’ tough skin and tremendous Regeneration kept them standing.

Boom!

Flames surged from another explosion. The leader smiled in satisfaction as its damaged hide healed in an instant, as though it would tolerate no wound at all.

At its broad, heavy feet lay the bodies of Hunters, their limbs twisted or their torsos split in two.

“Grrrk.”

Easy. Far too easy.

If this had happened not long ago, it would not have been able to deal with the humans who crossed through the Gate and invaded its territory so effortlessly.

“Ha. Ha. Ha!”

The world was changing. The monsters’ bodies held purer, stronger magical power than ever before, and humans could not stop them.

Everything was returning to its rightful place.

Over the past several decades, humans had gone from prey to hunters.

Now they were prey again.

“I. WILL. KILL. EVERY. LAST. ONE!!”

Years of oppression. Years of humans invading their territory and hunting them. The leader’s fury erupted in a roar.

Whoosh! Boom!

Its vision went black.

No—its head was gone.

The leader wasn't alarmed. A Troll could survive losing its head. Unless its body was pulverized, its tremendous Regeneration would keep it alive—

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! Boom-boom-boom!

Along with the sound of air splitting, the leader's consciousness snapped off.

For all its Regeneration and steel-hard flesh, the leader was helpless. Its body dropped to its knees before it could even wonder what had happened.

Silence followed its death.

"Kwo?"

The other Trolls looked around in confusion. A calm voice reached them.

"Let's finish this quickly."

Step.

With the footstep moving forward, a colossal force bore down on everything around them.

"My friend is waiting for me."

Chapter 759

The command center felt hot and muggy, like a steam sauna.

It wasn't. The oppressive heat was an illusion born of the anxiety weighing on everyone inside.

The temperature was kept perfect around the clock by Magic, yet cold sweat streamed down German Prime Minister Markus's forehead.

"Magical power levels are surging!"

"Class 1 disaster level expected within thirty minutes!"

"The area of increased magical power is expanding!"

"Intelligence has revised the enemy estimate! At least ten thousand!"

"A report from Commander Scholz! He's requesting authorization to use 'Uran' as a precaution!"

Markus bit his lip at the final report.

Uran.

The closely guarded code word meant uranium. In other words, nuclear weapons.

As a nation defeated in the Second World War, Germany was not supposed to possess nuclear weapons. But some truths could never be made public.

He wants to use Uran?

Commander Scholz, who was overseeing the blockade of Munich, was no fool who spoke without thinking. He was one of the few commanders with military successes to his name from the Great Cataclysm, and a man known for his cool judgment.

"Your Excellency."

At his aide's call, Markus squeezed his eyes shut. Then he forced out the words.

"Prepare Uran."

"B-but…"

"It's a precaution against the worst-case scenario. I'm giving you this order as the head of this country's government."

The generals and aides stared at him, wide-eyed. Then they nodded.

They knew as well as he did: against high-level monsters that might as well be demons, nuclear weapons were almost the only modern arms capable of dealing meaningful damage.

And…

If the worst does happen, even nuclear weapons might be useless.

A nuclear weapon was a double-edged sword.

If the enemy included a monster comparable to a high-ranking mage, it could use spatial teleportation to drop their nuclear missile over a major city.

If the attack succeeded, Munich—Germany's third-largest city—would be wiped out. If it failed… Markus didn't want to imagine what would follow.

"What about the citizens?"

"The evacuation is still underway. About ten percent of Munich's population remains in the danger zone."

"Move faster. Once this begins, there's no turning back."

"Yes, sir."

The capital, Berlin, had already taken a direct hit in the earlier terrorist attack. Markus couldn't stand by and let Munich suffer the same fate. The human and material losses from Monster Waves so far were astronomical.

We have to stop this one.

Even if it meant blowing the entire city away with nuclear weapons, the people had to survive.

A nation could exist because there were people living within its borders.

And to do that, they needed reinforcements. Hunters who were one-person armies, each capable of doing the work of a thousand—or ten thousand.

"What happened to them?"

No names were needed. Everyone in the command center knew whom he meant, and reports came from all sides.

"Michael Silbert is engaged in combat in Cape Town!"

"The battle is heavily in his favor! Estimated to end within thirty minutes!"

"Damn it. Why did it have to be Africa?"

Someone's frustrated mutter had barely faded when another aide spoke up.

"Jin Taekyung is on his way to Munich. Estimated time until he reaches the site is about one hour."

"What? A whole hour?"

"Didn't you say we only had thirty minutes until Class 1?"

"I-I'm sorry. He's traveling as fast as he can by fighter jet, but it's more than eight thousand kilometers[3127]…"

"Goddamn it!"

While those around him lost all semblance of composure, Markus wiped his forehead with a handkerchief already soaked through.

"Everyone, stay calm. The estimated number of monsters has increased, but we're not outmatched. Evacuate every remaining civilian while there's still time, and deploy every force we have."

Five thousand Hunters made up the main force surrounding the danger zone. With all the reserves waiting in the rear, they would have an army of ten thousand.

[3127] Eight thousand kilometers is about 5,000 miles.

And at its head stood Germany's own S-rank Hunter, Schumacher.

Thud.

Prime Minister Markus sprang to his feet and spoke in a resolute voice.

"We have every chance of winning. Thirty minutes. If we can hold out for just thirty minutes, we can minimize the damage and bring this to an end—"

"Emergency report from Commander Scholz!"

Along with the scream-like cry that swallowed the rest of the prime minister's words, a massive shock swept through the command center.

"M-magical power! It's passed the critical threshold!"

The critical threshold.

That could mean only one thing.

A Monster Wave.

At last, the solid dam—the barrier that had kept humans and monsters apart—had collapsed.

Rumble!

A tremendous tremor swept through Munich.

The concrete-covered ground split open. High-rises designed to withstand earthquakes toppled like dominoes.

Crash! Boom!

And beyond the thunderous noise, people could finally hear it. See it.

Shhhh!

The air split as though sliced by a sword, and the cries of countless monsters came from the opening.

—Grrrk.

Hissss.

Mist darker than gray, almost black, spilled out and seeped through the area.

Monsters with human arms and legs and the heads of bulls.

The Minotaurs emerged without end, breathing hard as they looked around.

This strange world was filled with noises they had never heard. Yet the magical power permeating it was sweeter than anything, and the countless humans in the distance stirred the ferocity they had been born with.

—Krrk, kaaaaa!

Kill them. Kill the humans and conquer this world.

Roaring as one, the Minotaurs charged toward the humans who had raised a wall of steel with their enormous shields.

Toward more blood and magical power.

Rumble!

As countless hooves pounded the ground, streaks shot across the sky with a heavy rush of air and plunged down upon the monsters.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Missiles poured in from the German Armed Forces waiting in the rear.

Massive explosions accompanied by flames swallowed everything around them. Everything left behind in the area, where most of the citizens had already been evacuated, was reduced to ash and melted beneath the horrific firepower.

At least, that was what the humans hoped—even knowing that weapons born of science could not stop these monsters.

Kaaaaa…

The bombardment, which had seemed endless, finally ceased.

Silence settled over the city. One of the Hunters staring into the mist that still lingered muttered, “They’re coming.”

Everyone had been thinking it. A moment later, it came true.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A fierce tremor shook the earth. Beyond the dark mist, more horns than anyone could count flashed into view.

Then came the roar of a monster whose presence dwarfed every other Minotaur’s.

—Kraaaaaa!

The Fear of the S-rank Minotaur Lord spread in every direction.

At the head of its army, the leader swept away everything blocking the broad road and kicked off the ground with all its might.

Boom! Whoosh!

The ground sank beneath it like a sinkhole.

As the monster’s massive body charged forward with a tremendous roar, a figure shot toward it at the speed of a beam of light.

“How dare you!”

The fury in his voice was unmistakable.

Once a gold medalist who had represented Germany in fencing, he had become a symbol of the country itself: S-rank Hunter Joel Schumacher.

His hand moved, and his sabre followed.

Swish!

A silver line cut through the air. The Minotaur Lord swung its enormous halberd to meet it.

Boom!

A muffled blast and a shock wave shook everything around them.

It was the signal for the battle to begin. The two species, bound to a fate neither could escape, charged at each other.

“Formation!”

“Don’t fall back! Kill them all!”

—Kaaaaa!

Rumble!

Swish-swish-swish! Crunch!

Roars and screams rose from every side, with death close behind.

It was the beginning of a horrific bloodbath that could end only after they had killed and been killed by one another.

Joel Schumacher fought as if possessed.

He lost track of time. He had no idea who was dying around him, or how many.

He couldn’t afford to look. If he took his eyes off the Minotaur Lord for even a moment, its enormous halberd would smash his body to pieces.

Whoosh! Crunch!

The halberd’s blade passed right in front of him with a heavy roar of air, making the fine hairs on his body stand on end.

Yet his body, trained through countless repetitions and battles, moved with effortless fluidity.

Swish! Bang!

He stepped and thrust his sabre. Compressed air burst from its tip.

The Minotaur Lord retreated a step with agility that belied its massive size, its face twisting.

—Krrk?

Confusion and pain mingled in its cry. A hole the size of a child’s fist had opened in its shoulder.

That worked.

A thrill ran down Schumacher’s spine.

His movement had been so fast and natural that he hadn’t even been aware of it, as though invisible strings had guided his body.

What was that? Have I lost too much blood?

The fight had not been easy. Honestly, it had been grueling.

The rusty spearhead of the halberd tore away chunks of flesh with even a glancing hit. Every clash of their weapons sent enough force through him to drain his Stamina.

Strength: overwhelmingly inferior.

Speed: slightly superior.

That was the balance so far, and exhaustion and blood loss were beginning to blur his vision.

But for some reason, he felt as though he could do anything now.

As if he could bring down that terrifying monster and become the superhuman who saved this land.

Yes. The Übermensch.

Friedrich Nietzsche, the father of German philosophy, had spoken of the Übermensch: a superhuman who rose even in tragedy, a great overcomer who strove to realize his fullest potential.

And at this moment, Joel Schumacher was rising to a new level through martial force, not merely as an idea.

He drew on everything he had built through training and experience, from his years as the world's greatest fencer until now. And on his will to survive.

Swish! Swish-swish-swish!

Streaks of light crossed the air.

Every time the sabre danced, swung with the least movement and the greatest speed, the Minotaur staggered backward, spraying blood.

Thrust! Slash!

He stabbed and cut.

To Schumacher's hazy eyes, the monster's body was riddled with openings. Every one of his heightened senses was fixed on a single target.

The Minotaur Lord.

Now!

Slash! Fwoosh!

A fountain of blood shot into the air. Schumacher blinked.

Huh?

Something was wrong.

The monster's blood should have been green or blue. The blood falling over his head was red as a rose.

Like human blood.

"…Cough."

Blood spilled between his dry lips.

The dreamlike haze vanished, and reality rushed in.

I've been cut.

He hadn't cut the monster. He had been cut.

Fiery pain spread from his back, and Schumacher staggered.

At the last moment, while all his senses had been focused on the leader, another Minotaur had slashed his back with a rusty sword. His comrades cut off its head and caught him.

“Schumacher!”

“Damn it! Get him out of—”

Whoosh! Crunch!

The hands supporting him vanished. So did his comrade’s breathing.

Schumacher lost his balance and fell. Gasping, he lifted his head.

The Minotaur Lord stood over him, leader of the monsters that had come to Munich, an enormous double-bladed axe raised high.

…Goddamn it.

This was the end.

For Munich. For the Hunters here.

And for the Übermensch his homeland, Germany, had wanted so desperately.

Schumacher gave a hollow laugh and closed his eyes.

No—he was about to close them when a stranger’s voice reached him.

“You’re going to die like this?”

His fading mind stirred. Schumacher blinked slowly through his blurred vision and saw someone standing between him and the Minotaur Lord.

The man’s back seemed broader than the monster’s. His presence was calm, yet overwhelming.

A spear rested in his hand.

And Schumacher understood.

“Jin… Taekyung.”

Asia’s Übermensch had arrived on the battlefield.

Chapter 760

"Über, what?"

He had definitely called my name before muttering something, but when I glanced back, Joel Schumacher was already collapsed against a pile of concrete with his head resting on it.

He really gave it everything he had.

I could see why. From what I'd seen, he'd been fighting in a Trance.

That dreamlike moment when enlightenment carried you into a greater realm.

Unfortunately, Schumacher had been ambushed before he could see it through. But when he opened his eyes again, he would probably be stronger.

"Should I wake him?"

"He couldn't get up even if you did. Leave him be, and make sure he doesn't die."

"You heard him, right? Handsome hu—no, Team Leader Choi?"

"…Understood."

That bastard had gotten so good at dumping work on other people, he was practically human now.

Still, the Skeleton King would be far more useful in the fight. Instead of giving him a hard time, I quietly sent him a Sound Transmission.

You know what to do, right?

You treat this body like a child.

Say it back to me.

His reply came back curt.

There are human eyes watching, so suppress your magical power as much as possible. And when using your power is unavoidable, make absolutely certain that no one notices.

Good.

Satisfied now?

This is enough to make you about middle-school age, not a child.

…How dare you. You're not even thirty. This body is an elder who has lived for over a hundred years.

Technically, haven't you been dead for over a hundred years?

"What!"

The Skeleton King's indignant shout came out loud enough for everyone to hear. I laughed quietly and let my spearhead hang at an angle.

"I've said what I needed to. Go on."

My voice sounded strange to me, as if it belonged to someone else. Dry as sand.

The hint of a smile that had touched my lips was already gone.

I crooked a finger at the enormous monster watching me warily.

“You. Come here.”

—Grrr…

The Minotaur Lord.

A low growl and a foul stench spilled from its maw. Its blood-red eyes were already full of caution.

—Who. Are. You.

“Me?”

At the center of a battlefield that had fallen into a lull when I appeared, I took a slow step forward.

“The Majang-dong Spearman.”

—…Strong. Hu. Man.

Most Minotaurs were cow-headed idiots who couldn’t even count, but a monster’s intelligence grew with its grade, whatever its species. S-rank monsters in particular had been granted exceptional power.

That was why the Minotaur Lord had stood rooted to the spot from the moment I appeared.

Instinct had already told it the truth.

It couldn’t beat me on its own.

“You caught on fast. You haven’t tried charging me.”

—…!

Step. Boom.

Our footsteps sounded together. The Minotaur Lord retreated exactly as far as I advanced, then suddenly roared like a wild beast.

—Kaaaaaa!

Fwoosh!

Magical power swelled around its massive body and spread to every corner of the battlefield.

At the same time, the thousands of Minotaurs that had sensed something wrong and begun to stop their attacks charged, their eyes gleaming with bloodlust.

Not at the Hunters they’d been fighting.

At us.

—Kwooooo!

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Their cries shook the earth. Watching the countless bulls surge toward us from every direction, the Skeleton King muttered, “But we haven’t left yet…”

“That’s why you should’ve gone sooner.”

“Can I use a little of my power, then? I think we need an army.”

“If you want to announce that you’re a monster, why not start an internet broadcast? You could rake in virtual gifts with a ‘Skeleton Army Creation’ stream.”

“Damn it. Too late to ask them to let us through, I suppose?”

Team Leader Choi answered the Skeleton King’s nonsense.

“Spend less time worrying about that and more time drawing your weapon.”

Shing.

A silver blade slid free as he spoke. The **Hero’s Sword** pointed toward the monsters, its aura dazzling.

Then Team Leader Choi’s calm voice reached every ear.

“Formation. Now.”

Clack-clack-clack!

The three of us weren’t the only ones who had come to save Munich.

Around two hundred Hunters from the Ares Guild and Peace Guild had come with us. They hadn’t had much chance to contribute against Leviathan, but they were the elite of the elite. Without a hint of hesitation, they readied themselves to meet the enemy.

“Please give us our orders.”

Team Leader Choi. The Skeleton King. Even the Hunters who had barely survived the crisis in the middle of their grueling fight.

Everyone was looking at my mouth.

Waiting for my command alone.

And right now, there was only one thing I could tell them.

“Kill every last one.”

Whooooooosh.

The fire dragon coiled in my lower dantian woke and spread through every part of my body.

Taking the crowd’s thunderous roar as my signal, I kicked off the ground with all my strength.

Boom!

Wind whipped past me. Dozens of meters[3128] vanished in an instant, bringing the charging Minotaur army right up to my face.

No. They hadn’t come to me.

I’d come to them.

Whoosh.

I exhaled, held my breath, and raised the spear I’d been holding at an angle. Powerful Scorching Yang Qi turned to flame along its transparent blade.

And then… I let it loose.

[3128] Dozens of meters is roughly tens to hundreds of feet; 1 m is about 3.28 ft.

Now.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, first form.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Whoom—fwoooosh!

A line of flame swept through the air with a blast of superheated wind.

Curving smoothly like a dragon's tail, the qi scythed across everything ahead of me. It melted horns that could pierce alloy with ease and burned through the monsters' bones and hides.

Kaaaaaaboom!

One strike.

The wave of flame swallowed dozens of Minotaurs. Not one screamed.

They burned black without so much as a final cry. Even the ones charging behind them stopped and faltered at the sight.

—Kwooooo!

Their leader roared at their backs, urging them on. But instinctive terror drowned out its command, and they paid dearly for that brief hesitation.

Slash!

Heads and limbs rose into the air.

I plunged into their midst and went wild.

One Minotaur finally came to its senses and swung a mace. I cleaved through it and the monster holding it, then struck another across its thickly hide-covered chest with the back of my hand.

Crack!

Bone shattered. Its massive body flew backward and smashed through the formation.

The Minotaurs shoved their dead comrade aside and scrambled to their feet. Countless spells and arrows came flying over their heads.

Whish, thud-thud-thud!

Boom! Bzzzzzt!

Those struck through the head or eye by aura-coated arrows had the easier deaths. Fire made from mana burned through hides, while lightning split into dozens of streams and lit up the battlefield.

—Krrk, krrrk!

Boom! Thud.

Monsters convulsed and fell one after another. A familiar face was the first to burst through the acrid smoke left by fire and lightning.

"Aaaah! You goddamn monsters!"

Whoooosh—crack!

Leaving aside how naturally he'd taken to slaughtering his fellow monsters, where the hell had he found that?

The Skeleton King gripped an enormous halberd. With one swing, he split three or four Minotaurs in half.

He was about to swing at the next ones charging him when blue aura shot through the smoke.

Slash!

A clean movement. Not a bit of force wasted.

Team Leader Choi cut neatly through a neck and spoke.

"Charge."

His voice was low but firm. Mana carried that one word across the battlefield, turning it into a rallying cry.

"Waaaaaah!"

"You fucking bastards!"

"Kill them all! Defend our home!"

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Countless Hunters surged forward with a roar, their ranks rolling in like a wave.

They weren't as tall or vast as the waves Leviathan had raised. But something stronger burned in their eyes.

The will not to surrender this land.

Grief for the comrades who had died here today, and vengeance reserved for the monsters before them.

And I was at their head.

Whoom—boom!

Compressed air burst from the end of a punch I drove forward like a beam of light.

A monster dropped like a rotten log, its head gone without a trace. I rained spear strikes on the enemies revealed behind it.

Whish-whish-whish!

Cut. Stab. Twist and crush.

Nothing could stop Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron wreathed in Force.

My spearhead sliced through sturdy weapons like tofu and split the monsters behind them. Even under the effects of a special debuff, my body had long since surpassed its limits—and those of the monsters.

As it did now.

—Kwooooo!

Whoooom!

A heavy rush of air bore down on my side along with the monster's cry. With three Minotaurs skewered on my spear, I reached out with my free hand the instant I sensed it.

Thud.

A fist the size of a manhole cover stopped against my much smaller palm.

Ridiculously easily.

—Kwo?

The Minotaur blinked with the innocent look of the yellow ox at Scholar Kim's house[3129].

I gave a quiet laugh at the sight and gently guided the force of its trembling fist upward.

Whoom!

The fist struck empty air a handspan above me.

The monster had lost its target. My foot hadn't. It shot forward like lightning and struck its chest with precisely the force and timing I wanted.

Crack!

Something broke with a sickening sound, and its body hurtled away. Far away, sweeping up every comrade in its path.

Straight toward the leader that had watched it all from behind.

And then…

Slash! Fwoooosh!

The lifeless body split in two. Through the fountain of blood, the Minotaur Lord glared at me.

Blood-red eyes. A double-bladed axe stained with its subordinate's blood.

But I knew what lay deep in those eyes.

Wariness had turned to fear, and that fear kept driving it backward.

"Want to run?"

—…!

"Sure. I can see why you would. But…"

Whoooom! Crack!

Dozens of Minotaurs that had rushed in from every direction to protect their leader were flung away. At last, after the monsters had been reduced to gruesome heaps of blood and flesh, the path ahead lay wide open.

I shook the blood from my spearhead and slowly continued.

"You came here however the fuck you pleased. You don't get to leave that way."

—You…!

Boom!

The belated cry was swallowed by the thunderous sound exploding from my toes.

[3129] The *nureongso*, the yellowish-brown native Korean ox, was a docile farm animal; a country scholar's ox is an image of placid, simple innocence.

I shot toward it like a beam of light, the distance vanishing between us. The Minotaur Lord gritted its teeth and hurled its double-bladed axe.

Whoooooosh!

Darkness rushed at me with a roar of displaced air.

No. Magical power.

Still flying low from that single push off the ground, I twisted my body.

Whoom.

A fierce wind thick with the smell of blood brushed the tip of my nose. I thrust my spear.

“Die.”

Crack!

This time, too, there was no final cry.

Chapter 761

No matter how powerful a monster was, unless it possessed regenerative abilities equal to or greater than a Troll's, it was bound to die if its neck or heart was pierced.

Just like now.

Whoosh!

The Minotaur Lord jerked its neck back. Too late to avoid the spearhead driving toward it.

No—my strike was too fast and precise to let it escape.

Crunch!

The spearhead pierced its throat, cut through flesh and bone, and burst out the other side.

Its eyes went wide with pain. Blood and phlegm rattled in its slightly open mouth.

Grrk. Grrrk…

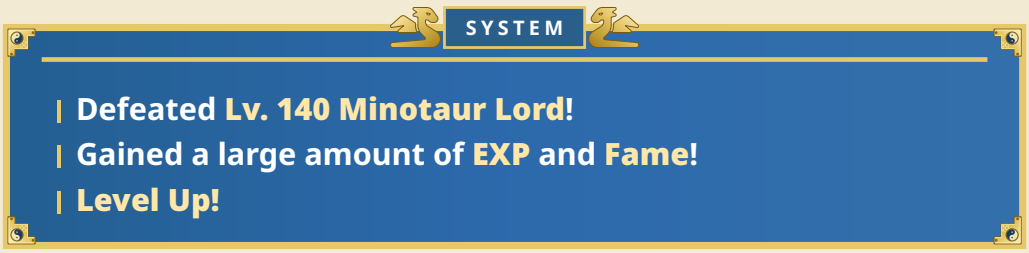
What tenacious vitality.

But it was time to put a period to it.

"Goodbye."

Boom!

The flame carried by my spearhead exploded. Its tree-thick neck snapped in an instant, sending its head flying.



As the System notification rang in my ears, I slowly turned around.

The battlefield had fallen silent. Humans and monsters who had been fighting fiercely moments ago were all staring at me.

At me, standing before the monster's crumpled corpse.

At me, who looked like hope to some and nothing short of disaster to others.

They had stopped as if by agreement. I kicked the Minotaur Lord's head where it lay on the ground.

Whoooosh—clang!

The severed head soared high into the sky and landed at the center of the battlefield.

Kickoff for the second half. No, for the final period of overtime.

But the stunned players needed a word from the referee to get moving.

“What are you waiting for? Wipe them all out.”

“…!”

—…!

Human and monster eyes widened at the same time, though for different reasons.

Joy for the humans.

Fear for the monsters.

And at the moment countless gazes filled with those different emotions left me and met one another—

“Waaaaaaaah!”

A roar loud enough to leave my ears ringing rose as a wave of humans certain of victory swept over the monsters.

Shreeeek! Crunch!

“All of you, come at me! You fucking monsters!”

“…”

Why was that bastard always out in front?

The monster world’s Yi Wan-yong, or something.[3130]

I shook my head at the sight of the Skeleton King hacking through monsters left and right with his halberd, then charged into their already half-broken ranks.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! Slash!

Right.

The battle wasn’t over. All that remained was the slaughter.

The slaughter began around sunset and ended deep into the night.

With their leader dead, the fear-stricken Minotaur army fell apart in an instant and scattered in every direction. Somewhere along the way, I had become the field commander. I settled their fate with one simple order.

“Chase them. Turn the whole city upside down if you have to.”

After that, it was a hunt.

True to their name, the Hunters ground the already shattered Minotaur army into dust.

“You bastards!”

“This is revenge for Jonas! Kill every last one of them!”

Whoooosh! Crunch!

—Kaaaaaah!

[3130] Yi Wan-yong was a Korean official who collaborated with Japan during its colonization of Korea.

A Hunter could die from a single stroke of bad luck. But how many people could accept a comrade's death as just part of the job?

All the grief they had felt today turned to rage. Victory became another word for revenge.

"Minotaurs spotted! They're headed toward the international airport!"

"What should we do?"

"Excuse me?"

"Your orders, please!"

"…?"

That caught me off guard.

Never mind the military commander handling the rear guard—these Hunters had their own team leaders. Why ask an outsider like me? Still, the answer was simple enough.

"What are you waiting for? Instead of wasting time asking me this, go kill them."

"Thank you! Team Three, follow me!"

"Waaaaaah!"

"Übermensch has ordered us to slaughter every last monster!"

"Follow Übermensch! Crush their flesh and bones, and drink their blood!"

"Übermensch! Übermensch!"

"Flesh and bone! Bone and flesh!"

"…"

What the fuck. That was scary.

Judging by the shouts echoing from every direction, this wasn't Germany anymore. It was the Aztec Empire at minimum.

Granted, they were hunting invading monsters rather than people. That was a pretty big difference.

"Still, it would probably be better not to drink the blood…"

"What was that?"

"Nothing."

Team Leader Choi gave me a strange look, wiped the blood from his face, and spoke.

"It seems most of them have been dealt with. The German Armed Forces deployed the rear guard they had held back, and I hear they're right on the verge of annihilating the rest."

"Quite a few escaped."

"They're tracking them all with drones. They won't get away."

I nodded and asked what mattered most.

"What about casualties?"

"About fifteen hundred reported so far. Nearly a thousand dead. The rest are seriously injured, but their lives aren't in danger."

Science and magic had come together in this world.

Most injuries could be treated with surgery, and with healing magic and potions added to the mix, even someone who had lost a limb could recover enough to move around without difficulty within a month.

But the number of dead weighed on me.

"A thousand…"

Far too many people had died.

I had arrived as fast as I could and fought with everything I had. I still hadn't been able to save them.

"Mr. Jin."

At Team Leader Choi's quiet call, I shook my head.

"I'm fine. I know what you're going to say."

Objectively, today's battle had been a decisive victory. We had crushed an army of nearly ten thousand Minotaurs, killed the S-rank monster leading them, and kept our losses to a minimum.

But a wound didn't stop hurting just because it was smaller than it could have been.

The exhausted Hunters still chasing monsters for revenge were proof of that. We had won a great victory, and we were in pain.

We had been for a long time. We still were.

That was war.

A wheel of suffering with no real winners or losers, where the outcome depended on who inflicted the greater wounds.

Knowing that didn't change my duty to fight. Or to stop the person reaching out from unseen darkness, setting that wheel spinning faster after its brief pause.

—What about him? Michael Silbert?

Team Leader Choi heard my Sound Transmission. Without so much as twitching an eyebrow, he moved his lips.

—He's on his way to Munich now that he's wrapped things up in South Africa, or so I heard.

—He was a step too late this time.

—This was never part of the plan.

Odin Guild was enormous. With branches all over the world, it could respond quickly—but even then, it couldn't have accomplished what we had today.

Michael had used the Prophet as a tool to bring about this disaster.

To everyone else, it might look like the indiscriminate terror attack of a mad fanatic. But Michael Silbert, who had manipulated everything from behind the scenes, knew exactly when and where the terror would occur.

The Monster Wave in South Africa was probably one of them.

But there were exceptions.

I had intervened in the Munich Monster Wave, something Michael Silbert had failed to predict, and stopped the disaster before he could.

No.

And in doing so, I had gained the power to stand in his way: the public's renewed support and trust.

"…"

"What is it?"

"Nothing."

I looked around. A ruined city. Bodies and pools of blood in every street.

I felt sick. As though I had used the deaths of more than a thousand people to further my own ends. As though I, too, had become a monster no different from Michael Silbert or the Prophet.

But…

I had done everything I could. Call it self-justification. Call it telling myself I'd won. I didn't care.

I had tried to save as many lives as possible and fought through gritted teeth to prevent a greater disaster.

And as a result, I had become the only—and greatest—obstacle in this world capable of standing against Michael Silbert.

Open Quest window.

Ding.

A familiar chime sounded, and a holographic window unfolded before me. The same Main Quest, unchanged since I had first seen it.

Cataclysm.

I repeated the word reflected in my eyes.

I had killed the Minotaur Lord, the greatest cause of this Monster Wave, and wiped out nearly ten thousand monsters. Still, the System had said nothing.

As if there was still a long way to go.

As if it would only finish the mission assigned to me after I had shattered all of Michael Silbert's plans and brought him to complete ruin—or ended his life.

I was staring silently at the window when—

Whoooooom.

"…!"

I turned my head. Far off in the dark sky, beyond what an ordinary person could see, a faint light was approaching.

What is that?

A question. A guess. Then certainty.

My tangled thoughts worked through all three before reaching an answer.

Team Leader Choi noticed something was wrong a moment after I did and spoke in a subdued voice.

“He’s arrived.”

“Yes.”

Crrk.

My grip tightened on the spear shaft until my knuckles went white. I watched the light draw closer and muttered,

“He’s here.”

Simon, a reporter nearing his tenth year on the job, was bursting with excitement and nerves.

This is a scoop. A scoop.

His smartphone was full of notes and draft headlines he had been typing for hours.

An army of monsters led by the S-rank monster Minotaur Lord.

Estimated number: ten thousand. A massive force.

Central Munich. Urban battle breaks out.

The battle turns against humanity. And then Jin Taekyung finally appears.

S-rank Hunter Joel Schumacher in crisis, saved by a true transcendent being. Is Jin Taekyung Übermensch?

A great victory! A scoop! Are you seeing this, News Director? You bastard, you’re worse than a pig’s asshole. Why the fu— am I getting blamed because Daniel Daisuke got the rally canceled?

Tap. Tap-tap.

Simon stopped typing and deleted the last note.

The news director had shouted at him half a day ago over the cancellation of the rally against Jin Taekyung. But the man had also sent him here, and remembering that took some of the edge off his irritation.

Yeah, all right. Upper management’s been riding him hard lately.

Covering for your superior was also part of a subordinate’s duty. Simon nodded and entered a new note.

The meeting of two heroes.

Jin Taekyung and Michael Silbert meet again in Munich!

And just as Simon typed the final exclamation point, a powerful wind blew toward him and the countless other reporters.

Whoooosh.

“They’re here!”

“Is that Odin Guild?”

“Definitely! That’s the Guild Master’s private aircraft!”

Shouts broke out all around him. Simon watched in awe as the massive aircraft slowly descended toward a nearby open lot, then hurried after the reporters surging forward like a wave.

He had no idea what was about to happen there.

Chapter 762

Damn.

Huginn clicked his tongue softly.

Through the windows, specially treated to keep anyone from seeing inside, he could see the ground drawing closer and an astonishing number of reporters waiting below.

They've come out in force.

Not that reporters gathering for Michael Silbert was unusual. His name attracted them even in ordinary times. Since the terrorist attacks began, the mere sight of the Guild Master's private aircraft was enough to send them rushing over.

But Huginn couldn't remember seeing a crowd this large in years.

The problem is, those cameras aren't pointed at us.

The media wielded tremendous power. The easily swayed public treated cameras as its eyes and speakers as its ears.

And if every spotlight here fell on Jin Taekyung?

Troublesome. Very troublesome.

Huginn took his smartphone from his pocket.

"Leave them be."

"…!"

A voice suddenly slipped into his ear, and Huginn's heart lurched.

How?

He knew the voice. He had served its owner for years. What startled him was that he hadn't sensed Michael Silbert's presence at all—not even the faintest trace of it.

And Huginn was an exceptionally skilled S-rank Hunter himself.

"…You've arrived, sir."

Michael caught the agitation Huginn couldn't quite suppress.

"Was I that unexpected?"

Huginn considered his answer. "No."

"You looked surprised."

"For a moment, I was. Not anymore."

"Why is that?"

"Because you're the Guild Master."

"You really are a born flatterer."

"I mean it. I'd stake my life on it."

"Don't go staking such a precious life so easily."

"It's all right. I gave it to you long ago."

Michael let out a quiet laugh at the ready answer and looked out the window.

"It's rather noisy outside."

"I was just about to have them sent away."

"I thought you might. Knowing you."

Then he added, "Leave them be."

Huginn ran his fingers over the smartphone in his hand. A single phone call would be enough to send all the reporters gathered outside away.

Even if they used force, not a line about it would appear in the papers. That was Odin Guild. That was the world they lived in.

But his superior's wishes mattered more to Huginn than anything else. Even so, he couldn't understand this order.

"May I ask why?"

"Why?"

"Why you came all the way to Munich when there's nothing to gain here. Why you intend to meet Jin Taekyung in front of all those reporters."

The question had been with Huginn since they left South Africa. They hadn't foreseen the Munich Monster Wave, and by the time their aircraft took off, Jin Taekyung was already several steps ahead of them, bringing the whole crisis to an end.

In short, today's stage belonged to Jin Taekyung.

"Public opinion toward him has taken a sharp turn. The demonstrations against him that broke out around the world after the Leviathan incident have been disbanding one after another. Even the media outlets working with us are being cautious now."

"So?"

"Today, at least, he's drawing more attention than you are, Guild Master. Must you meet him here and draw even more eyes?"

"You make it sound as though I'd be nothing but part of his supporting cast. A spotlight to make him shine brighter."

"…I'm sorry, but yes."

Huginn lowered his head. He had spoken out of loyalty, but he couldn't bring himself to face the anger he expected.

But this is reality.

The tide had already turned.

Michael's Odin Guild had built an impressive record during the terrorist crisis by suppressing more than ten Monster Waves. Yet Jin Taekyung had restored his steadily declining reputation in only two battles.

Leviathan's infamy from the Great Cataclysm, when it had all but ruled the seas, had played a part. So had Jin's overwhelming victory over the Munich Monster

Wave, whose scale had surpassed all expectations. But Huginn believed there was a deeper reason public opinion had changed so quickly.

Jin Taekyung.

People who already had plenty tended to inspire envy and resentment before admiration. Jin Taekyung, though, was familiar to them. A hero who gave everything he had.

He had grown up in a family that struggled to make ends meet. From the moment he Awakened, he had supported them, going from Gate to Gate without a day off. As recently as a year ago, he'd lived on ramen in a shabby goshiwon[3131] room of barely five pyeong.[3132]

Young, poor, and among the lowest-ranked Hunters, he had been someone people could find anywhere in the world. Even after he gained tremendous wealth and Fame, the Jin Taekyung from those days remained etched in their hearts.

When he stormed a massive Guild alone in pursuit of revenge. When he stained a desert red with blood to achieve his goal. Even when he broke countless laws and procedures along the way, he faced no more than condemnation.

Huginn was certain that was why.

The world… the public loves Jin Taekyung.

The media offensive hadn't shaken his core supporters. Those who had condemned him out of fear of terrorism crumbled like sandcastles after just one or two displays of what he could do.

Of course. It's Jin Taekyung, after all.

They accepted him again—and blamed themselves for ever wavering.

It's a kind of pardon. An invisible pardon the public has given him.

No one but Cheon Taemin had ever possessed it. Michael had worked so hard to obtain it. Jin Taekyung already had it.

Which is exactly why we can't make him stand out any more than he does.

A slight vibration ran through the aircraft, and the pilot's voice came over the speakers.

"Landing successful. The door will open shortly. Please let me know when you're ready."

"Not yet. Keep the door closed and wait—"

"Open it."

"…!"

Huginn jerked his head up. Michael saw his bewilderment and gave a hearty laugh.

"Huginn, my cautious friend."

[3131] A goshiwon is a small, inexpensive rented room, often with shared facilities.

[3132] Pyeong is a Korean unit of area. Five pyeong is about 16.6 m^2, or 178 ft^2.

“Guild Master!”

“Don’t worry. I have no intention of becoming anyone’s spotlight.”

“What do you—”

“I’m opening the door. Please stand clear of the entrance.”

Psssh.

Huginn’s unfinished voice was swallowed by the noise that erupted the instant the door opened, like a dam collapsing.

Click, click-click-click!

“Michael! Michael! Please look this way!”

“TBC Broadcasting! Could we have a word?”

“I understand this is your second meeting. What kind of relationship do you normally have with Mr. Jin?”

“Nearly every crisis has been resolved. Why come to Munich now?”

“What do you think of Mr. Jin’s performance?”

“According to the German government, the Munich Monster Wave was nearly ten times the size of the one in Cape Town! Don’t you think it took far too long to suppress?”

Flashes fired without pause. Reporters shouted questions over one another, and Huginn’s face hardened.

Most of the questions being thrown at them revolved around Jin Taekyung. One audacious reporter had even gone so far as to compare them.

“…Whatever you have in mind, Guild Master, it would be best to postpone the interview.”

Michael calmly shook his head and strode toward the exit.

With a single remark that seemed to have nothing to do with the current situation.

“I watched the video you obtained in Japan. Very interesting.”

“Pardon?”

“Come along. We can’t keep him waiting any longer.”

Step.

Michael descended the aircraft stairs without hesitation and stood before the cameras and flashing lights.

Beyond the reporters clamoring for a scoop, and the German Armed Forces soldiers holding them back, he spotted someone approaching. He broke into a broad smile.

“At last, the young hero has arrived.”

Flash!

The night was illuminated by the most dazzling burst of flashes yet.

Reporters gasped and hurriedly parted. The two heroes walked slowly through the opening until they stood face-to-face.

“We meet again, Jin.”

Slide.

Michael greeted him warmly and held out a hand. Jin Taekyung stared in silence at his smiling enemy, then took it.

His voice was low and hoarse, almost as though it were boiling.

“…Michael Silbert.”

Crack.

Their tightly clasped hands went white.

Everyone lives behind a mask.

To get along with others. To earn a living. Or to avoid a fight they don’t want.

But Michael Silbert’s mask was harder and thicker than any I’d ever encountered. I couldn’t begin to guess what lay behind it.

Crack.

The bones in our clasped hands shifted with a grinding sound. Feeling the force transmitted through his grip, I widened my eyes.

What the hell…?

The force was unbelievable. With everyone watching, I wasn’t using my full strength either. But his grip was far stronger than I’d expected, and I couldn’t hide my surprise.

How?

The physical abilities I’d developed through the System were, quite literally, superhuman.

That was why neither a Supreme Peak master nor an S-rank Hunter could approach me in pure physical ability.

That was what I’d thought until I took his hand.

—That seems like enough of a greeting, don’t you think?

“…!”

—We’re in front of the cameras. We should both be a little more careful.

I came to my senses and looked around. We’d been holding hands for nearly half a minute, and a few reporters were watching us with suspicion.

“Ah.”

“My friend here must be glad to see me. I feel the same way.”

Pat, pat.

Michael smiled and gave my shoulder a friendly tap. A few reporters smiled too.

But he and I were having a conversation their cameras and microphones couldn’t capture.

—What the fuck are you playing at?

—Who can say? I do not understand what you mean. Is coming to congratulate a young junior on his victory some kind of trick?

—A passing dog would laugh at that, you son of a bitch.

—You really won’t believe me.

—Sorry, but I’m not that much of an idiot. You’re already a step too late.

Michael let out a quiet laugh and moved his lips.

—Actually, you’re right. I came to make a very important announcement.

—An important announcement?

—One that will turn the whole world upside down.

—…What?

What the hell was he talking about?

I stared at him, stunned. Then Michael’s smile vanished. He looked straight into the cameras.

And he dropped a bombshell no one there had seen coming.

Chapter 763

A thought is only a thought until it becomes reality. But the moment it forms a complete sentence and flows out as a voice, it gains influence.

Just like now.

“I have witnessed countless deaths.”

A sorrowful voice rang out. Standing tall before countless cameras and microphones, Michael Silbert slowly continued.

“In the slums of Paris, teeming with flies and gangs. On the countless battlefields of the Great Cataclysm. And ever since the day of victory when the Demon King Asmodeus fell. I have continued to witness them.”

Bzzzz.

The faint hum of the cameras sounded unusually loud.

No one so much as swallowed. The reporters watched Michael with an anticipation they couldn’t quite explain.

This is…

Something’s coming!

At first, they’d wondered why he had suddenly started spouting nonsense. All they’d wanted was a friendly shot of the two heroes—one old enough to be the other’s father—with their arms around each other’s shoulders, and perhaps a few warm words.

Jin Taekyung was supposed to be the star today. Michael was merely the spotlight that would make him shine all the brighter.

Until he opened his mouth.

“Yet through all those deaths, I held on to one hope. One dream. With the Demon King Asmodeus and his monster army gone, I believed that someday every conflict would end and true peace would come.”

His tone rose and fell distinctly, and his expression was filled with appeal.

Michael Silbert’s appearance, compelling everyone who saw and heard him to focus, was reflected in the camera lenses.

Around the world, people watching live leaned closer to their living-room televisions, their computer monitors, the smartphones in their hands.

“Mom. Dad. I need to watch my cartoon…”

“Shh, Peter. Be quiet for a moment.”

> ㄴWhat the fuck is No Jaehun doing? I called for a gank, and the bastard went AFK. ㄴWhat’s up with Jaehun? Fight with his girlfriend? Are we surrendering this match?

“It’s not that. I was watching an iTube live stream. Never mind—I’ll put the link in the group chat. Take a look.”

> ㄴ What girlfriend? That bastard doesn’t have one. It’s just not his promotion match, so he doesn’t give a shi—Munich live? What’s this?

Dozens of television channels and streaming sites carrying the broadcast lit up with activity. Their audiences multiplied, and the viewers watched with bated breath.

On-screen, Jin Taekyung stood grim-faced while Michael spoke one step ahead of him. Michael’s voice carried to them all.

“I have waited a long time. I have hesitated. But I stand here today to tell you one thing—for our faith in peace, and for a better future.”

Michael drew a breath. So did everyone watching him.

Then his voice emerged, dry as sand.

“A second war is nearly upon us.”

“…!”

“…!”

Invisible agitation and shock waves swept through every direction.

An office worker flipping through channels after work. A couple passing beneath a huge billboard. A teenager who had paused his game and opened the stream to kill time. The reporters standing right in front of Michael.

At that moment, they doubted their own eyes and ears before falling into extreme confusion.

A second war.

Everyone knew what those few words meant. Someone gave voice to it in something like a groan.

“The Great Cataclysm…?”

How could they not know? It was humanity’s clearest nightmare, a memory seared into them by fear: the worst Great War in history, which had covered the Five Oceans and Six Continents in blood and corpses.

And now Michael Silbert was saying that very Great Cataclysm would begin again. He was declaring that a second war had arrived.

Before them. No, before the entire world.

That’s… impossible.

It can’t happen. It can’t.

Yet no one could bring themselves to say it. Denial had come with another, paralyzing thought.

What if he’s telling the truth?

A second Great Cataclysm could not happen. It must not happen.

But people had sensed something wrong. Deep down, they had been feeling their way around the shape of that fear.

The signs were already there.

Magical power levels rose by the day. Strange phenomena grew more frequent. Only a few months ago, an Arch Lich had appeared in Sichuan Province, China, and Monster Waves triggered with Magic Gems had followed one another across the world.

Scholars had studied that method of terrorism long ago. The leading experts in magical power had agreed it was impossible—unless the world's magical power reached a certain limit.

Today, Michael Silbert was telling them it had.

"Perhaps calling it a *second* war is wrong. But one thing is certain: what you and I believed was the end of the war was only a ceasefire."

"…!"

"I tell you now: the magical power throughout our world has already passed its critical threshold. A disaster like the one we faced before will engulf the entire world."

People could barely breathe.

This wasn't some drunk rambling in a neighborhood bar. It was a declaration from Michael Silbert—a hero of the Great Cataclysm who had remained at the forefront ever since, a giant who led the world's greatest Guild.

One of the stunned reporters managed to ask, his voice shaking, "D-Does that mean the Demon King… Does it mean Asmodeus is coming back?"

"On the Day of Victory, during the final battle that decided humanity's fate, the Demon King was undoubtedly erased without leaving so much as a trace. I saw it clearly with my own eyes, so that is an indisputable fact. However…"

Michael Silbert hesitated for a moment before adding, "Now, no one can be certain. No one can be certain what will happen in the future, or even whether the Demon King Asmodeus was truly erased."

"Ah… Ahh."

"How can this be…?"

Cameras shook. The reporters' dismayed voices came through the microphones and went out to the world.

No one watching from elsewhere complained about the disruption. They were no calmer than the people on-site. The terror they had refused to face had finally taken shape, and they trembled at the truth they had tried to ignore.

An unpredictable future. No—a disaster.

And the possibility that the Demon King Asmodeus might return.

Fear spread through their minds like dark clouds. Whether they watched Michael Silbert on a screen or stood before him, their eyes shook. They wanted him to take it all back. They even entertained the absurd hope that he might laugh and say it had been a joke.

His next words crushed it.

"Peace—or what we thought was peace—is over."

Michael looked into the camera. His sorrow and anger seemed almost tangible.

At least, they did to the people watching him.

"The war has already begun. We must fight, without hesitation and without taking a single step back."

His voice trembled between his lips like a wave. Michael Silbert poured out his words as though sobbing, as though pleading, then clenched his teeth.

"Together! More united than ever before!"

His reddened eyes burned, and his cry thundered through the microphones.

The cameras no longer showed Jin Taekyung. Every light, every spotlight, was fixed on one man.

Michael Silbert.

In the eyes of the people, he looked like a fighter filled with determination.

In his own mind, he was already a hero and a king. A hero offering a path to people in crisis. A sovereign who would reign over the world.

Amid the trembling air and countless watching eyes, Michael took his final step. He spoke the words he had waited for this day to say.

The World Hunter Federation.

Everyone caught their breath. The air seemed to go still beneath the overwhelming aura radiating from him.

"A federation encompassing every nation, bound by no restrictions. The very World Hunter Federation that saved us—all humanity—from the Great Cataclysm. Its return…"

He let the words trail off. His eyes shone as he gazed toward the hundreds of millions, perhaps billions, watching him around the world. Then he released the breath he had been holding.

"I dare to propose it here today."

"…!"

"…!"

The return of an international organization that stood above every law and restriction.

An unseen shock swept through the crowd, then traveled through cameras, microphones, and broadcasts to every corner of the world.

And just as everyone watching was seized by shock and an emotion they could not name, a voice shattered it all.

"Go fuck yourself."

Hundreds of reporters. The German soldiers and police holding them back. Even the other Hunters who had arrived late.

Countless eyes turned toward me.

Beyond the gleaming camera lenses, I could almost feel the unseen gazes and voices pouring in like a wave.

I didn't care. Or rather, I couldn't spare them a thought.

So that was it.

I felt as though I'd been hit in the back of the head. My vision swam.

Inside my mind, which looked as though a kindergartner's playroom had been turned upside down, the words I had just heard rang out with perfect clarity.

The World Hunter Federation.

Thirty-odd years later, all that remained of those old heroes' organization bore the name International Hunter Federation.

Age, gender, nationality, race—even the law had meant nothing to the Hunters who followed humanity's savior, Cheon Taemin. That was the World Hunter Federation.

They had fought solely for humanity's survival and won at the cost of countless lives. Then, as soon as the Demon King Asmodeus fell, they had gone their separate ways.

And he wants to bring that World Hunter Federation back?

Of course I respected the people who had fought in it, just as everyone else did. They had fought for all of us. And when the war ended, they had surrendered that immense power without regret.

But this was different.

The World Hunter Federation Michael Silbert dreamed of was nothing more than a kingdom for one man.

So I said it again, in front of everyone.

"Go fuck yourself."

"…!"

"…!"

People stared, unable to believe what they'd heard. Then a quiet voice reached my ears and threw my thoughts into turmoil all over again.

—Think it over one more time before you speak.

Michael Silbert.

The man who had driven the world into crisis so he could climb that crisis like a staircase to a throne.

The schemer in a hero’s mask smiled at me. His snake-like eyes glinted as he looked past my shoulder at someone behind me.

—If only for the sake of your monster friend.

Chapter 764

For a moment, the world seemed to stop.

The hundreds of people staring at me with their mouths open. The cameras and microphones jutting up between them. The dazzling lights illuminating the broad lot in place of moonlight.

Everything around me slowed and blurred.

Everything except the one man who had brought my world to a halt.

Michael Silbert.

The most cunning, unscrupulous man I had ever met stared back at me.

His eyes, usually so calm, held unmistakable amusement and triumph. His voice came through just as clearly when it reached my ears again.

“You seem surprised.”

I came to my senses and belatedly steadied my breathing.

A painful mistake.

Whatever he said, I couldn’t let him see me shaken.

Show an enemy an opening, and he’d find your weakness. I needed to be especially careful when that enemy was Michael Silbert.

It’s not too late. As far as I know, the Skeleton King’s identity is secure, and he hasn’t shown me any proof.

I had to stay calm from here on out. Whatever he said next, all I had to do was answer without letting it rattle me…

Damn it.

Crack.

Bones shifted audibly in my clenched fist.

I could tell myself whatever I wanted. It was already too late. From the moment I’d met his gray eyes, my instincts had been screaming that his remark wasn’t a mere probe.

Michael Silbert had come here certain, not guessing.

His next words settled it.

“You have two choices. Of course, you don’t have much choice at all, but you might as well hear them for the fun of it.”

His voice was relaxed. With his back to the cameras, Michael moved his lips, looking more pleased than I had ever seen him.

“First, your friend’s identity is exposed before the entire world. Second, you leave this noisy place, and the two of us have a private talk.”

“…!”

“So? What will it be?”

Damn it.

The curse slipped out in a whisper. Michael gave me a faint smile and stepped closer.

Brush. Pat.

His hand reached out slowly and brushed the dried blood and dust from my shoulder. At last, the reporters came to their senses and let loose the shouts they had been holding back.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung! Does what you just said mean you oppose the World Hunter Federation?”

“W-Wait! Please tell us exactly what you meant by that profanity!”

“Mr. Jin!”

Click. Flash-flash-flash!

The cameras kept rolling as flashes burst from every direction.

The dam of silence broke, releasing a wave of noise. Michael quietly raised a hand to settle the crowd, then spoke.

“My friend here is already a hero the whole world is watching. He is also a spirited young man. The battles and events of recent days must have exhausted him, so I ask for your understanding.”

“Are you saying Mr. Jin has post-traumatic stress disorder?”

“I’m sorry, but let’s leave that discussion for another time. There is only one thing I came to tell you today.”

Michael looked into the cameras.

“The war has begun again. For humanity to survive the coming flood of blood, we need an ark: the World Hunter Federation.”

“…!”

“That is all. Have a good night, everyone.”

That was his final word to the crowd.

Leaving the reporters shouting behind the German Armed Forces and police officers who blocked their way, Michael Silbert turned and walked toward his private aircraft, which had landed in the center of the open lot.

He left me with one last remark that only I could hear.

“I’ll make you some coffee. I hope you won’t keep me waiting.”

Grind.

My teeth clenched.

I knew why he’d said it.

“Mr. Jin!”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung! Please, just one statement!”

I turned away from the cameras as though fleeing and saw two figures hurrying toward me.

Confusion and shock were written across their faces. They spoke too quietly for anyone else to hear.

"We've been played. This was what it was all for."

"Damn it, what the hell is this mess? What's this World Hunter Federation thing, anyway?"

Their questions came in a rush, but I said nothing.

What could I say?

Where should I even begin, and how should I explain it?

As I wrestled with that, someone's face came to mind.

"Magic Johnson."

"What?"

The Skeleton King frowned at the name.

"Why bring him up all of a sudden? First, tell me what's going on… Wait. Is there something on my face?"

I'd been staring at him without realizing it. I shook my head.

"…No. Nothing."

I still didn't know whether to tell him what had just happened. Or what choice I—what choice *we*—should make.

But some feelings couldn't be hidden just because you wanted to hide them.

Team Leader Choi finally realized I was keeping something from them. His face hardened, and his lips moved.

"What is it? What happened that made you ask for Mr. Johnson?"

"…"

"Tell me. Right now."

My thoughts were tangled, but they didn't have long to wait.

After several dozen seconds that felt like an hour, I sent my voice toward Team Leader Choi through Sound Transmission.

"The Skeleton King's identity has been discovered."

"…!"

"Contact Magic Johnson. I need everything his investigation has turned up from the materials we took from the late Siegfried Bassmann's hideout, and everything he knows about Michael Silbert. All of it. Not a single thing left out."

Team Leader Choi's eyes trembled. He remained silent as though he had lost his voice, then slowly nodded. I took a deep breath and began walking.

The lot was now empty of people.

I headed toward the enormous private aircraft standing at its center like an impregnable fortress.

Toward the man waiting inside.

Michael Silbert.

Yes. The bastard was right.

The war had already begun.

Michael Silbert kept at least one promise.

"Come in."

The first thing I saw when I entered his private aircraft, as spacious as a suite, was a cup of coffee on the table.

It smelled freshly brewed. Beyond the steam rising from it, gray eyes—somewhere between darkness and light—watched me.

"I'm glad you came so quickly. I was worried it might get cold."

I sat down and quietly looked at the full cup. As the silence stretched on, Huginn, who had been standing at attention behind me, spoke.

"If it isn't to your taste, shall I prepare another coffee?"

His words were polite. The mockery in them wasn't subtle.

I gave him no answer. I looked away from the cup and jerked my chin toward Michael.

"I don't care if you keep a pet, but that crow won't stop cawing. It's getting on my nerves."

Whoosh.

The air grew heavier. A faint sound reached my ears as Huginn came one step closer behind me.

"If you don't want to walk on your arms from now on, get back where you were. And shut your mouth before I rip it open."

"…!"

"What? You think I can't do it?"

I was speaking to Huginn, but I kept my eyes on his master. Michael stared at me for a moment, then blinked.

"You're serious."

"I am."

"You would cripple Huginn right in front of me?"

"I might kill both of you."

An ordinary person might not have taken that provocation lying down. Someone who knew my fatal weakness might have used it to threaten me. Someone powerful enough that I couldn't afford to lower my guard might have threatened me with force.

Michael was both of those things, yet neither reaction suited him.

"Huh."

I couldn't read anything into the sound he made. He studied me with interest.

"Whether you could succeed aside, isn't that a little reckless?"

"If I'd been cautious, I wouldn't have made it this far."

He let out a short laugh.

"True. From what I've seen, the last few years of your life have been one reckless act after another. Perhaps that's how you won the public's love and trust."

"Maybe. But is that all? There must be things even you haven't seen."

"I once heard of an Eastern saying: empty bluster. Let's not waste time on meaningless words. I already know everything about you."

He was wrong.

Michael Silbert knew nothing.

He did not know what kind of life I had truly lived, or how much recklessness it had taken to overcome every crisis and survive until today.

No one in this world could even guess at that secret. One day, it would be a dagger I drove into an enemy's heart.

Michael couldn't know that. When I laughed, the smile left his face.

"Why are you laughing?"

"Because I'm enjoying this."

"Does *this* include the fact that the Stone-King is a monster?"

He was trying to rattle me. But I'd already made that mistake once, and once was enough.

Someone else was less composed. I felt a startled movement behind me and shrugged.

"Looks like your friend didn't know."

"He does now."

"He's been getting on my nerves for a while, so I couldn't say anything."

"Leave now, Huginn."

After a moment's hesitation, Huginn bowed his head and left the aircraft. Michael spoke again.

"As you know, I could have told the cameras everything."

"Yeah."

I nodded.

"And one of us would be finished by now."

"Exactly. But I didn't. Do you know why?"

"Scared shitless?"

Clink.

The teaspoon he'd been stirring through his coffee stopped. His gray eyes fixed on me.

"You really are… an unusual man."

"And you really are… a fucking asshole."

Honestly, I didn't know if this was the right move.

But even a cornered rat would bite a cat. Calling Michael Silbert a tiger wouldn't have done him justice, but right now, I was the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

Hiss.

Terrible heat surged through the palm I had laid on the table. Vapor rose around it, overpowering the steam from the coffee. I spoke quietly.

"Go ahead. If you're ready to die."

Chapter 765

Whoosh.

The air inside the private aircraft grew heavy, pressing down on everything within.

The auras flowing from Michael Silbert and me faced each other across an invisible line. Neither of us gave an inch. The standoff felt ready to erupt at any moment.

But if we crossed that line and clashed, there would be no turning back. One of us would die.

I had no intention of backing down. Now that he had found a fatal weakness, one step backward would be the end of me.

Tap. Tap. Crash!

The coffee cup cracked, then burst apart.

At the same instant, I sensed dozens of people racing toward us like streaks of light.

Bang!

The alloy door was ripped off in an instant, and a piercing sound rang out.

In the blink of an eye, the loyal hounds had entered the aircraft, wagging their tails at their master.

“Is something wrong?”

I knew that voice. Over my shoulder, Michael Silbert calmly addressed Huginn, who had returned only minutes after leaving.

“I told you to wait outside.”

“My apologies. I thought there was trouble.”

“Nothing of the sort. Our guest accidentally dropped his coffee cup.”

“I see.”

Huginn glanced at the glass scattered across the room.

“I’ll bring another.”

“No need. Whatever you bring, our friend won’t like it.”

“Then…”

“Go back outside. Don’t return until I call for you.”

Huginn hesitated at his superior’s quiet, firm order, then led his men away.

Once the guards had left the aircraft, Michael spoke again.

“I think we should stop here. What do you say?”

“…”

“Whatever happens if we continue, we’ll both lose a great deal. Is that really what you want?”

I stared at him, then slowly reined in my aura.

I hated it, but he was right.

As long as the world did not realize what he truly was, even if I killed him here and eliminated the threat of future consequences, I would be branded the worst kind of murderer and criminal.

I would have to spend the rest of my life running from pursuit and surveillance worse than those aimed at a public enemy of the Murim, while my family and friends lost their ordinary lives completely.

That was what frightened me most, and Michael knew it.

"That's better."

He brushed the glass from his clothes, then crooked a finger. A fresh cup and a coffee machine half-full of coffee floated over.

"Good thing I prepared spares. Would you like some?"

"If you've got more cups you want to throw away."

"I'll take that as a no. They were hard to come by. I hate seeing them break."

Trickle.

He filled his cup carefully.

"Now that you've calmed down, let's get to the point. Help me."

Go fuck yourself.

The words rose to my throat, but I swallowed them.

Michael already knew the Skeleton King's identity. He also knew that, however angry I was, I couldn't kill him here. Those two facts were the main reason I couldn't just get up and leave.

Damn it.

My fist trembled beneath the table. I kept my voice as even as I could.

"What if I help you?"

"The World Hunter Federation takes root. Without any controversy. Cleanly."

He dropped a sugar cube into his coffee.

"And I become the head of the new federation, of course."

"You sound awfully sure of yourself."

"Oh, Jin."

He gave a quiet, derisive laugh and shook his head.

"You already know who would take the top seat if the federation were founded now."

"…"

"Only you and I are qualified. And…"

Clink.

He slowly stirred the sugar into his coffee. After a sip, his face settled into an expression of perfect satisfaction.

“Once this useful conversation is over, I’ll be the only one still qualified.”

“…!”

“Are you sure you don’t want any? The aroma and flavor are perfect.”

Grind.

My teeth clenched.

I felt like the sugar cube in his cup. It would dissolve whether it wanted to or not, completing the flavor of his coffee.

And the finished coffee—the World Hunter Federation—would flow into Michael Silbert’s mouth. An armed organization powerful enough to ignore nations and restrictions alike would fall into the hands of a monster wearing a hero’s mask.

If this goes the way he wants… it’s over.

During the Great Cataclysm, the World Hunter Federation had earned its praise by serving as humanity’s sword and shield. Its members had chosen the public good over private gain. They had risked their lives for a greater cause instead of chasing wealth and power, then disbanded after the Erasure of Demon King Asmodeus.

Michael Silbert was their opposite.

A man who caused disasters without hesitation for the sake of his own interests and power. A monster consumed by endless desire was sitting across from me.

In place of the true hero, who had fallen into an indefinite coma, that monster sat across from me.

“…Cheon Taemin.”

The name escaped me like a groan. Michael’s face stiffened for a moment before he smiled faintly.

“Ah, yes. Sky. He was there.”

Click.

He set down his cup with an easy hand, and his voice was just as relaxed.

“In fact, I intend to ask him to lead the federation first.”

“What did you just say?”

“Why so surprised? He has more than enough qualifications. The living savior who rescued humanity from Demon King Asmodeus. The greatest hero in history, and the man who led the World Hunter Federation during the Great Cataclysm. Who could be better suited?”

It felt as though someone had struck me in the back of the head with an iron club.

I finally understood what Michael wanted. I bit my lip.

“You son of a bitch… Don’t tell me.”

“Isn’t it tragic? A hero of his stature should be leading humanity and saving the world once more, yet his illness prevents him from stepping forward. What a cruel whim of God.”

“…!”

“But the fortunate thing for the people is that Sky recommended someone else as his replacement. The captain who will lead the newly born ark known as the World Hunter Federation. Another hero of the Great Cataclysm known throughout the world, someone else who stopped the spread of terrorism through a noble spirit of sacrifice.”

My breath caught.

None of it had happened yet, but as he spoke, I could see the whole thing unfold.

Michael Silbert would nominate Cheon Taemin as Alliance Leader of the federation. Cheon Taemin would decline on account of his illness and recommend Michael for the position instead.

And after that…

“I think I’ll refuse three times or so. Humbly, of course. Once we’ve put on that little show, you can step forward. It’ll make a fine picture.”

Michael smiled at me. I couldn’t smile back.

He wanted more than my help. He wanted me to put him on the throne.

Once all those gears, large and small, had turned together, every accusation that he’d revived the World Hunter Federation for his own power would disappear. Everyone would seem to have urged him to take the throne.

Without any disturbance or suspicion.

With the support of Cheon Taemin, humanity’s living savior, and of me, his greatest obstacle, he would have an unassailable claim. The next savior—and a king with immense power at his command.

“You crazy son of a bitch…”

The words came out like a groan. Michael smiled.

“Don’t worry. If you and your friends cooperate, I’ll fulfill my duties as Alliance Leader of the World Hunter Federation.”

“You expect me to believe that?”

“Oh dear. It seems I haven’t done enough to earn your trust.”

“What?”

“You know everything I said in front of the cameras today was true. Magical power levels around the world have crossed the critical point. Humanity needs the World Hunter Federation.”

He drained his coffee and added calmly, “And I need the World Hunter Federation.”

“…!”

At those words, something hot surged up from deep in my dantian.

Grind.

I glared at him, fire in my eyes. My fists were clenched so tightly they'd turned white, ready to erupt like volcanoes.

For the sake of the power he wanted—*that* paltry thing—dozens of cities had been destroyed and more than a few million people had died.

And that wasn't all. Black smoke from the collapsed forests of buildings and the burning streets had blotted out the sun. Survivors who had barely escaped the sudden disaster now huddled in bomb shelters and their homes, clutching family and friends as they trembled in fear.

And he said *what*?

"You fucking bastard…!"

Fwoosh.

Blue-white flames surged from the fist that had been trembling all this time. Powerful Scorching Yang Qi burned the air and melted everything nearby.

Rage seized my entire body. Killing intent rose with it, and I drove my fist forward.

Whoom! Roooar!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

A single punch carrying heat fierce enough to reduce anything to ash tore through the space between us.

Toward the monster in human skin. Toward the madman who would sacrifice anything to get what he wanted.

I'll kill him here. No matter what.

For that moment, I forgot everything else and gave myself over to rage.

And in a world that seemed to slow without end, I saw it: a dazzling streak of light intercepting my flame-wrapped fist.

BOOM!

A tremendous blast shook everything around us. I withstood the shockwave driving against my body and stared wide-eyed at Michael Silbert.

At the last instant, he had drawn his sword like lightning and caught the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist on its blade.

Sizzle-sizzle-sizzle!

A gray aura, the color of its master's eyes, gleamed ominously. From beyond the blade pressed against my blue-white flames, his low voice reached me.

"I'm warning you. If you don't stop here, there really will be no going back."

Shhhk!

There was still one last line we hadn't crossed. As his warning sank in, I sensed Huginn and the guards approaching behind me. I closed my eyes.

In the darkness, the faces of my family and friends flashed before me.

Damn it.

My fist relaxed and slipped away from the blade.

Chapter 766

At some point, I had begun fighting without end.

When I had no power, I fought in Gates for the happiness of my people. After gaining power, I fought to protect them.

But… what an irony.

I had never backed down in the face of death. Now a few words were enough to make me retreat.

Slide.

The blue-white flames that had burned so fiercely died down.

Without giving an inch, I slowly drew back the fist pressed against Michael's sword.

"A wise choice."

His loathsome voice made my stomach twist. I lowered my fist, still trembling with rage.

No. The moment the tension in the air eased, I threw another punch.

BOOM!

Another deafening blast rang out, and a wave of scorching heat swept in every direction. An enraged shout erupted behind me.

"How dare you!"

Shh-shh-shhik!

Killing intent surged toward me with the hiss of weapons cutting through the air—

"Enough."

At Michael's quiet command, Huginn and the dozens of guards with him stopped dead.

Michael Silbert gave his men a calm glance that told them all they needed to know, then spoke to me.

"I believe I warned you."

Grrrrrk.

Fist and blade locked together once more. Powerful blue and dark energies shuddered against each other. I glared at him.

"Yeah. You did."

"Do you intend to see this through to the end? Here and now?"

I clenched my teeth.

In my mind, I had already killed Michael Silbert dozens of times. I had broken his limbs, crushed his mouth, and ripped out his heart before bursting it apart.

But this wasn't Murim.

No—whatever world we were in, no one would accept what I wanted to do unless I tore off the mask he wore first.

“If that had been my intention… I would have done it long ago.”

“You’re more reckless than I thought. And even more arrogant.”

“I’d be disappointed if you thought this was just arrogance.”

Michael’s expression shifted.

Slice.

A faint line of blood appeared on his smooth neck with a sound so soft I could only hear it because I was close.

His skin had finally split under the immense pressure of that instant’s clash.

“Huh.”

“That’s my warning to you. Remember it.”

I spat out each word. Michael answered calmly.

“I take back what I said about arrogance. I should add something else instead. You’re more interesting than I thought.”

“You son of a bitch…”

“And thank you for the kind warning. It’s made one thing clear, at least.”

“What?”

“Jin. You can never kill me.”

Amusement crept into his dry voice.

“Because… somewhere along the way, you acquired far too much to lose.”

“…!”

A chill I couldn’t explain raised the hair all over my body.

It felt as though something sticky and repulsive had reached out and seized my limbs. The horrible sensation of being dragged into a deep swamp made me knock his blade away on reflex.

Crack!

Our two energies mingled for an instant.

In the last flash of light, familiar faces flickered before my eyes. I stumbled before I knew it and drew a ragged breath.

I didn’t want to admit it. I couldn’t.

And yet… I had to.

Michael Silbert was right.

The moment I ended the life of the man watching me so calmly, as though the blood on his neck meant nothing, I would cut short my own life and the lives of everyone close to me.

Like the countless enemies I had defeated, they would burn to ash and vanish without a trace.

"May I take your silence to mean I was right?"

I said nothing. Michael Silbert smiled.

"I look forward to working with you. I'll be in touch soon."

Swish.

He held out his hand, smiling like a man certain of victory.

I turned away without taking it.

No moonlight came to Munich that night.

Jin Taekyung was gone.

Huginn watched him disappear into the darkness, then spoke.

"Will he cooperate willingly?"

Michael Silbert nodded.

"Without a doubt."

"But Jin Taekyung's recklessness defies all expectations. Hasn't he always been difficult to predict?"

"Everyone has a weakness. And he possesses one more fatal than anyone else's."

"What weakness?"

"His feelings. Jin Taekyung is more emotional than anyone."

Michael continued in the same calm voice.

"Someone whose joy, anger, sorrow, and pleasure are so clear is easier to handle than a materialistic person. Wealth and honor can be regained even after they are lost, but people cannot."

He looked at his private aircraft, all but wrecked by the force of their clashes.

It had been custom-built with cutting-edge equipment and Magic at a cost of hundreds of billions of won.[3133] Its destruction stirred nothing in him. It was only a heap of scrap metal.

People were different. Each had only one life to live.

"Jin Taekyung… has more to lose than I thought."

Perhaps even more than I do.

Michael swallowed the words before they could leave his tongue.

He didn't want to admit it.

He already had more wealth than he could ever spend and immense power besides. Once he took control of the reborn World Hunter Federation, he would be beyond anyone's reach. He would be king of this world.

How could Jin Taekyung have more to lose than him?

That makes no sense.

[3133] Hundreds of billions of won is approximately $71 million–$710 million or €65 million–€640 million.

Michael patted Huginn on the shoulder.

“There is no need to worry. In a few days, everything will be concluded successfully.”

“I hope so, but…”

Huginn kept staring into the darkness where Jin Taekyung had vanished.

“I don’t know if letting him leave was the right choice. I can’t shake the feeling we’ve made a mistake we can’t undo.”

“There’s no need to feel that way. We had no other choice, either.”

“What do you mea—”

Crash!

An unfamiliar sound cut him off.

Huginn turned. His superior stood holding a sword with nothing left but the hilt.

“Guild Master!”

Michael shook his head at Huginn’s alarm. With a strange look in his eyes, he gazed at the fragments scattered around his feet.

“Well, this is something…”

Only two clashes.

That was all it had taken to shatter his cherished sword, forged from the finest materials and imbued with Magic. Without the powerful aura surrounding its blade, it probably wouldn’t have held together even this long.

He really is more interesting than I thought.

Michael had thought he knew the extent of Jin Taekyung’s abilities.

Odin Guild had kept its eyes and ears on him since he first came to prominence. With every new report, Michael had revised his assessment of the young Asian man.

First a potential recruit. Then a promising next-generation S-rank Hunter.

And then… his greatest obstacle.

I thought Cheon Taemin was the only one left.

That was how it had been. That was how it should have been.

Yet today, calculations that should have allowed no margin for error had proved completely wrong.

Jin Taekyung.

Michael looked into the darkness that had swallowed the young man moments ago.

He pictured him from head to toe—not yet half Michael’s age—and thought again of the enormous power coiled within him.

What if I had used all my strength?

A moment later, he gave a faint scoff.

It was a pointless question. He had reached his current position precisely because he had never used all his strength against any enemy.

The one who uses all his strength wins the battle, but the one who hides his strength wins the war.

Michael Silbert wanted to win the war. Not the battle—the war.

He had lived for dominion, not mere survival, and only one final step remained between him and the throne.

Everything is within reach. No need to hurry.

At least not tonight.

Michael Silbert swallowed the words circling the tip of his tongue and suddenly raised his head toward the sky.

To his gray eyes, Munich's night sky shone more brightly than ever. Someone else had looked at that same sky only moments before and seen no moonlight at all.

Yes. At least not tonight.

Crack. Fsssh.

In his clenched fist, the impossibly hard sword hilt crumbled into powder and scattered on the wind.

Michael Silbert was not careless enough to leave an obstacle where it stood after it had blocked his path once.

Even after I had finished telling them everything, the spacious suite remained filled with heavy air and silence.

It couldn't be helped.

I looked at Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King, both of whom had gone rigid, and muttered inwardly.

It was the reaction I had expected.

Nobody stays calm when their head's on fire. And in this case, being a monster instead of a human wouldn't make any difference.

"Damn it."

The Skeleton King broke the silence first. He muttered the curse, then spoke with a troubled look on his face.

"Wicked human. What happens now?"

"Hmm."

Under normal circumstances, I would have made a joke. But the matter was too serious this time, and I found it difficult to answer.

The Skeleton King probably had plenty on his mind. His identity had been discovered, and he had no idea what would happen to him next.

I couldn’t bring myself to say any of that. I just sat there, moving my lips without making a sound. Then he spoke in a grave voice.

“If it’s too difficult to answer, tell me just one thing.”

“Go ahead.”

“Will this body never be allowed to enter the club again?”

I blinked. For a moment, I couldn’t make sense of the question.

By the time I came to my senses, White Flame’s spearhead was driving into his chest.

Crack. Crunch.

“AGH! Aaaagh! It was a joke! I was joking!”

“Die. Please, just die…”

“Please spare me! My ribs! I’ve got a cracked rib!”

“You thoughtless bastard. Even Myeongnyun Jinsa Galbi[3134] has more sense than you…”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung! Mr. Jin Taekyung! You mustn’t!”

I must have lost it for a moment.

After a brief, rage-induced out-of-body experience, Team Leader Choi’s pleas finally brought me back to my senses.

Seeing the Skeleton King clutching his chest and trying to force his ribs back into place made my vision turn white again, but I endured through the superhuman mental fortitude befitting a Supreme Peak master.

Fuck. I think I’m about to suffer qi deviation.

Another ten minutes of watching that, and my qi and blood would have tangled so badly I’d have died or ended up crippled. Michael Silbert would have done a ridiculous little dance and recruited the Skeleton King as his new right-hand man.

Fortunately, a visitor arrived before qi deviation did.

[3134] Myeongnyun Jinsa Galbi is a Korean all-you-can-eat pork-rib restaurant chain.

Chapter 767

Bzzzt.

At the sudden vibration, Team Leader Choi pulled a smartphone from inside his coat. He checked it—one of the five phones he carried, no less—then mouthed my name.

Mr. Jin Taekyung.

The reason he wasn't speaking aloud was obvious. I quickly drew up my internal energy and spread it around us.

Fwoooosh.

An invisible barrier of qi sealed the suite without leaving a single gap.

Bzzzt.

Blue light poured from the smartphone lying on the table. In the blink of an eye, it gathered into a human-shaped hologram, and a deep voice rang out.

"Sorry I'm late. I just saw your message… But what happened to that guy? Don't tell me you've already had a fight."

Magic Johnson.

The towering Grand Mage blinked at the Skeleton King, who lay clutching his chest. I answered weakly.

"It's a long story."

Unlike the Skeleton King and Team Leader Choi, Magic Johnson's reaction was brief and clear.

"Fuck."

Of course, he didn't stop there. After muttering nonstop about a son and a beach, and about a third hole he normally kept hidden from view, he rubbed his perfectly smooth, hairless scalp.

"This… is about as bad as it gets."

Only then did something I hadn't considered occur to me. If the Skeleton King's existence were exposed, I would not be the only one to suffer a serious blow. Neither would Team Leader Choi.

"I'm sorry. I should've been more careful."

"No need to apologize, Jin. I chose to help you."

Johnson waved off my belated apology, then frowned.

"But how did he find out? My illusion Magic should have been perfect."

Magic Johnson was one of only three Grand Mages in the world. No—now there were only two. He had gone to great lengths to inscribe that illusion Magic, and its

effectiveness and secrecy were second to none. No wonder his face showed so many conflicting emotions.

"With Siegfried dead, there's only one mage left who could see through my illusion Magic… And I guarantee you, even Michael couldn't get her to act."

If Magic Johnson was speaking with such certainty, it had to be true.

I had heard plenty about the other Grand Mage myself, and after decades had passed, most of what I had heard had turned out to be fact rather than rumor.

But even leaving her aside, we had enough clues. And I wasn't the only one who saw where they pointed.

"Japan."

"Leviathan."

Although the words were different, they meant the same thing. Team Leader Choi, who had spoken at the same time as me, continued slowly as everyone's eyes turned toward him.

"As you all know, what happened in Japan wasn't simply a terrorist attack or a Monster Wave."

"Choi told me about it. I think Michael Silbert was most likely behind it, too."

"But what we need to reconsider now is his objective."

"His objective?"

"Why did Michael Silbert wake Leviathan from its sleep deep beneath the sea? And…"

"Why lure it to Japan, of all the countries he could have chosen?"

I picked up where Team Leader Choi had left off. The five oceans covered a staggering seventy-one percent of the Earth's surface. There was no shortage of countries with coastlines. So why had Michael chosen Japan as the place to let Leviathan run wild?

And there was the second terrorist attack, which struck around the world on the same day.

The answer was already there, as Team Leader Choi's next words made clear.

"He calculated everything meticulously from the beginning, taking Japan's situation at the time and every other factor into account."

Johnson grasped what he meant and spoke with a groan.

"Then all of it—including the second terrorist attack—was meant to draw you in?"

"Yes. I'm certain."

"But why Japan? If that was his goal, wouldn't it have been easier to lure Leviathan to Korea?"

Team Leader Choi shook his head and continued in a calm voice.

"From Michael Silbert's perspective, it was the only possible choice. Even setting aside the fact that Korean Hunters are far stronger, our government has been on

high alert ever since Go Jun artificially caused two Monster Waves. If magical power had suddenly surged, they would have noticed immediately."

"The Magic Gem…!"

"Exactly. But Japan had recently been hit by the first terrorist attack. The area around Tokyo, in particular, would have suited him in several ways."

It wasn't just any Magic Gem. It was an unrefined S-rank Magic Gem. The sheer amount and concentration of magical power it gave off had been enough to wake Leviathan deep beneath the distant sea.

But near Tokyo, magical power levels were already running wild because of the Monster Wave caused by the first attack. Another surge would have been hard to spot. Most importantly, there hadn't been a Gate near Tokyo Bay—the area Leviathan destroyed—that would have given anyone cause for alarm.

"Yes," Johnson said. "It all fits."

"He drew the outline based on that from the start, then colored it in with the second terrorist attack. Since Japan was fairly far from the major Hunter powers, it would not have been difficult to predict that its own forces would be unable to stop a Named Monster like Leviathan."

The Supreme Peak masters of Murim were proof enough that people at the same level could differ enormously in strength. Modern S-rank Hunters were no different.

And Japan's S-rank Hunter, Yamamoto Genji, was stuck on the lower floors of that pyramid of power.

If he was really as strong as all those Japanese netizens and Japan-worshipping fanboys dickriding him claimed, why had he shown up so late that Leviathan was already dead when he'd had an entire day to get there?

The answer was obvious.

The Japanese government must have known it, too. That was why they'd swallowed their pride and asked for help.

A country that had come through both worldwide terrorist attacks with little damage. An indisputable Hunter powerhouse, and a neighbor close enough to reach them faster than anyone else.

Korea.

And Korea had me.

No. *Us.*

"…!"

A chill ran down my spine. I abruptly raised my head as though I had just woken up and stared at the Skeleton King.

He'd been listening in a daze, too distracted even to put his dislocated bones back in place. At my stare, he flinched and shrank back.

"I—I've just been sitting here."

"…"

"I told you, I was joking because everyone looked so serious! Haven't you heard of lightening the mood?"

"That's not it."

"Th—then why?"

Damn it. My teeth had clenched without me noticing. My voice came out low and strained.

"It was you. From the beginning."

"This body? From the beginning? What are you talking about?"

The Skeleton King frowned. Team Leader Choi answered, his expression grim.

"Michael Silbert's target was never Mr. Jin Taekyung. It was you."

"…What?"

"Don't you see? The second terrorist attack. Leviathan. He arranged all of it to target you."

"…!"

The Skeleton King's pupils trembled. Johnson, who had been thinking in silence, let out a sigh.

"So he'd suspected it for some time."

"He would have needed evidence to turn that suspicion into certainty."

"Even at the cost of so many lives?"

"Do you still not know what kind of man he is? Hundreds could die. Tens of millions could die. Michael Silbert wouldn't bat an eye."

Team Leader Choi looked at me. His voice was rough as iron filings, nothing like it usually sounded.

"If it meant achieving his goal—if he could get the proof he needed—he could end all of this right now."

"…!"

He was right.

That was all the bastard had wanted: the weakness that would guarantee his victory in a war against me. So he'd set the entire stage, cutting off any chance of reinforcements from other countries and creating a situation where the Skeleton King had no choice but to step in.

And then… he finally got his hands around that weakness.

That wasn't all. His willingness to launch the second terrorist attack must also have had a great deal to do with the World Hunter Federation.

The worse the damage, the greater the chance of reestablishing it.

How far ahead had Michael Silbert calculated?

The question stole my breath. It felt as though an invisible cord were tightening around my neck. I took a deep breath and looked around.

Team Leader Choi. Magic Johnson. Finally, the Skeleton King.

At some point, all three had fallen silent. They were looking at me.

No. They were waiting for me to speak. Waiting for me to decide where we went from here.

Thoughts and doubts raced through my mind. At last, I broke the long silence.

“I…”

Three days passed.

No one said a word about the tremendous boom that had echoed across the vacant lot outside Munich, where the Odin Guild Master’s private aircraft had landed on the night disaster struck.

The reporters who had all but been driven from the scene wanted to know what had made the sound they’d faintly heard from a distance. But the German Armed Forces, which controlled the Munich area, gave them a firm answer.

First: no pointless questions, and no approaching the site.

Second: anyone who failed to comply would be deported immediately.

Even the most hot-blooded reporters, who had bristled at the first point, fell quiet at the second. With the proposed revival of the World Hunter Federation shaking the world, getting deported over something like this would be madness.

Two people central to that debate were still in Munich. One was Jin Taekyung, whose behavior in front of the cameras the previous night had baffled everyone. The other was Michael Silbert, the man who had lit the fuse on this powder keg.

“Hey, sorry, but have you heard anything about either of them?”

“No.”

“Do you mean there’s nothing to hear, or that you know something and won’t tell me?”

“Hmm. Both?”

“Come on, we’re colleagues. We ought to help each other out. Those Germans can’t take a joke, and they’re being ridiculously strict. What’s your name, anyway?”

“Franz Meyer.”

“…You’re not German, are you?”

“I believe I am. A strict, foul-tempered German who can’t take a joke. That’s me.”

“I didn’t say foul-tempered—damn it. Sorry. I didn’t mean that.”

“It wouldn’t matter even if you did. But if you’re really sorry, throw me a decent scoop.”

“A decent scoop? Then how about the emergency convening of the UN General Assembly?”

The bearded German reporter gave a short laugh.

“You’re joking. Who doesn’t know about that? The meeting’s been going on for ages.”

He was right.

At midnight three days earlier, following the Munich incident, the UN—reorganized after the Great Cataclysm—had called an emergency General Assembly. The leaders of 185 countries, led by the six permanent member states, were locked in fierce debate over videoconference.

They had gathered for one reason: the proposal to reestablish the World Hunter Federation.

Given what was at stake, the emergency session was being held under unusually tight secrecy. But word always leaked out. Major news outlets had already learned of it and were watching closely.

“And you call something everyone knows a decent scoop? Your sense of humor is worse than I thought. You’re in no position to make fun of Germans.”

“Hmm. What if I told you the vote is about to begin?”

The German reporter stopped as he was turning away. He stroked his stubbly beard.

“…Now that’s interesting.”

“Glad you think so. It isn’t a joke.”

“You’re sure?”

“Is anyone ever sure of anything? If you want a number, I’d say ninety-nine point nine percent.”

99.9 percent.

The German reporter repeated the near-certain figure under his breath and swallowed.

“That means…”

“Yes. That’s right. The UN will announce it soon.”

Simon, the reporter who looked a good ten years younger than the German man facing him, went on slowly.

“The result of the vote on the birth of the World Hunter Federation. An organization that would span the globe.”

“…!”

Chapter 768

Marie Antoinette Syndrome.

The name came from the story that Queen Marie Antoinette's hair suddenly turned white a few days before her execution during the eighteenth-century French Revolution.

No one had established the true nature or cause of the strange phenomenon, but at that moment, Baek Hanseong, the President of Korea, was certain it was extreme stress.

His own situation felt similar enough.

Fuck.

The curse he had kept to himself since his closely watched debut in politics swirled around in his mouth.

The sharp-eyed secretary who had worked with him since his days in the National Assembly gestured for him to cover his mouth. Baek ignored him.

The room was full of foreigners. None of them knew Korean well enough to read his lips, and they were far too busy to watch his mouth in the first place.

Why would they, when presidents from around the world had abandoned all dignity and were pointing fingers at one another?

"You call that an argument? Of course we have to reestablish the World Hunter Federation!"

"I'm not saying we should never establish it! I'm saying we should put it on hold. Do you know what *on hold* means?"

"Did you just speak informally to me? Are you insane?"

"You're the insane one. What are we going to do about the Federation's enormous authority? We haven't even properly reviewed the proposed changes. We can't just approve this in a few days!"

"You fucking… What's your country's GDP?"

Shouts flew through the translators. Faces glowed red.

Baek held a perfect three-for-three record in the brawls for which Korea's National Assembly was famous, so the sight was oddly familiar. But after days of it, he felt as though his head might burst.

What are they, children?

It wasn't always like this. Sometimes sharp words were exchanged and an uncomfortable atmosphere formed in accordance with international affairs, but the UN General Assembly was supposed to be a place where nations demonstrated their dignity and their leaders showed their character.

However, as the situation spiraled toward the worst possible outcome and the presidents were crushed beneath immense stress and pressure from all sides, they

had no choice but to throw off the masks they had been wearing and reveal their true faces.

“We’re all going to die! What happens if we put off establishing the Federation even now?”

“Exactly! Saudi Arabia strongly supports the establishment of the World Hunter Federation—”

“The Middle East should know when to bow out. You’ve sold more than enough oil, and now you’ve even exported terrorists to the entire world.”

“What?”

At the words of the Russian president, who was old beyond measure, a middle-aged man wearing a turban bulged his eyes.

“How dare you, you dictator!”

“A dictator? That’s rich coming from a king. At least I was elected in a fair vote. I wasn’t born into a royal family and handed this seat.”

“Ah, are you talking about that fair election where the voter turnout reached 140 percent in the last presidential election?”

“Well, these things happen. It was a long time ago.”

More than twenty years earlier, Vladimir Furin had become Russia’s president for life in an election whose astonishing turnout exceeded the country’s entire population.

He swept his gleaming eyes around the room. Long past a hundred, he kept himself healthy with cutting-edge medical technology and Magic potions, and his voice remained strong.

“What matters is that I—and Russia—oppose establishing the World Hunter Federation.”

“You…!”

“Let’s be frank. I don’t think the Federation is unnecessary. I’m concerned about who will take charge of it.”

Tap. Tap.

His wrinkled fingers struck the table. The force of the gesture carried through the hologram, silencing the supporters who had been about to protest.

“When we first discussed establishing the World Hunter Federation, I supported it because I trusted Sky. I met him myself. He had little interest in power.”

“And the circumstances were far worse,” said the President of the United States, Doramp Jr.

Furin nodded. “They were. That damned Asmodeus was sweeping across the world.”

"The situation is still serious, but it is not as bad as it was then. I hope everyone will consider that the World Hunter Federation possesses far too much authority for us to make such a hasty decision."

The Cold War between Russia and the United States had ended more than a century ago. Their long-standing resentment had not vanished, but here, at least, the two presidents agreed.

For Baek, the first to call for a delay, that was welcome news. So was the support of another ally who had already promised to stand with Korea.

"Our People's Republic of China must once again express its deep concern."

Chairman Xiao Yang looked toward Baek.

"As President Baek of Korea has repeatedly stated, the establishment of the World Hunter Federation must be discussed with great care."

"Er, Japan also agrees with Kankoku's[3135] position—"

"Thank you both."

What the hell is that bastard about to say now?

President Baek Hanseong hurriedly cut off Prime Minister Koizumi before he could dump shit all over the discussion. He leaned toward the microphone fitted with a translation device.

"As I've said several times, we must handle the question of the World Hunter Federation with care. Deciding it after only three days would be far too hasty—"

"Only three days? Hasty?"

The French president cut in with a scoff.

"Do you have any idea what has happened outside during those three days?"

"That—"

"I don't know how things are in Korea, but France has already had five major riots. Doomsday fanatics are out in the streets screaming, and work and production have all but stopped."

"…Please, hear me out."

"If it's what we've been hearing for three days, I must respectfully decline. Half the Louvre Museum has burned. What else is there to hear?"

President Baek Hanseong was rendered speechless. Without realizing it, he rubbed his throbbing temples.

That damned bastard.

He knew perfectly well that Odin Guild's support had helped the French president reach office. But he could hardly argue when the man was telling the truth.

Michael Silbert.

A single statement from a hero with enormous public support had lit the fuse on a world full of fear and anxiety.

[3135] *Kankoku* is Japanese for Korea.

Half the world's population had watched him warn of a second Great Cataclysm in real time. Within a day, the fire had spread beyond the metaphor.

Huge demonstrations bordering on riots. People driven into the streets by fear and anger had little patience left, and fires soon broke out across their cities.

The police? The military?

Armed officers and soldiers demanded that the crowds disperse, but their calls fell on ears already half-deaf to reason.

If France, one of the world's ten most developed countries, was in that state, there was no need to guess how others were faring.

"What the people want now is a result. A result that will reassure them. A result that will guarantee the lives of themselves and their families."

"If the World Hunter Federation isn't reestablished, our country is finished. At the very least, the presidential palace will burn, and I won't escape unscathed."

"We have no choice but to support it wholeheartedly. The movements of our military factions are already deeply suspicious."

"You're opposing it now? Have you lost your mind? Do you think you can watch from the far bank while the rest of us burn?"

The spotlight was bright. Everything around it was dark.

A handful of developed nations enjoyed a civilization more advanced than ever. But how many of the UN's 185 member states shared in all of it?

Demon King Asmodeus had fallen, yet hunger and civil war remained. More than a few countries were still struggling to keep their governments intact while nursing the deep wounds left by the Great Cataclysm.

For them, this was more than a powder keg exploding.

It was a nuclear blast—one that would soon swallow their entire country.

At this rate, it would not be monsters burning down presidential palaces. It would be furious citizens and coup forces.

"We can't delay any longer!"

"Let's vote!"

"We do not trust the Security Council or the permanent members! We demand a full vote!"

The calls came from all sides. Baek knew the long meeting was nearing its end.

This… can't be stopped anymore.

The UN Security Council still held enormous power. The United States, the United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China had been permanent members since their victory in the Second World War. Korea had joined them after the Great Cataclysm.

Of those six, the United Kingdom had remained neutral on this question and France supported the proposal. The other four stood on the side effectively calling for a delay.

But even the permanent members' veto power had clear limits under the reorganized UN.

So this is how it ends.

The secretary-general's announcement that voting had begun sounded distant. All Baek could hear clearly was his conversation with Choi Minwoo three days earlier.

"We need to delay the UN's decision as long as possible."

"Delay it? Not stop it?"

"If we could stop it, I'd ask for nothing more. But even with the United States and China helping us, that would be nearly impossible."

"…You want to buy time."

"Even a few weeks. No, even a few days would be enough. Please do everything you can until we reach the limit of what is possible."

"Hah. What exactly is happening right now?"

After a long silence, Choi's answer had been brief.

"War."

"…Mr. President. Mr. President."

Baek snapped out of his thoughts. His chief secretary was watching him, concern and impatience mingling on his face.

"You need to vote. We're the last."

"Ah."

After letting out a short groan that sounded almost like a sigh, President Baek Hanseong looked at the presidents filling the office.

No—the holograms.

Then, thinking of Choi Minwoo and Jin Taekyung, who were probably preparing for war somewhere by now, he cast the final vote of this miserable meeting.

Sometimes you did not need to see someone's face, or hear more than a few words, to understand them.

A voice's tone and pitch could tell you enough.

In that sense, Choi Minwoo understood everything the moment he answered the call from President Baek Hanseong.

"I did everything I could."

A long silence followed. The few words they exchanged after that felt hollow.

When the short call ended, Choi walked toward a room crowded with documents and monitors. Inside, someone was so absorbed in what he was doing that he had not noticed Choi arrive.

Then, suddenly, Choi opened his mouth.

“The UN… has approved reestablishing the World Hunter Federation.”
The reply was short.
Fuck.

Chapter 769

Even the most clearheaded person could not stay composed every moment of every day.

Michael Silbert realized he was shaken only after brewing three cups of coffee in a row.

Shaken? Me?

The realization surprised even him. That surprise soon turned to displeasure.

A leader must never show himself wavering. Not to enemies, not to allies, and not even to himself.

To win this war, he could not show the slightest opening.

In the heat of battle, a person's movements began to slow the moment they realized they had been wounded.

Michael believed he could have everything only if he could ignore any pain. He had lived by that belief ever since the day he returned from the brink of death, long ago.

But today, two things had shaken him.

One was the thrill of being so close to his grand dream.

The other…

It's probably that bastard.

A face flickered through the steam rising from the coffee cups.

A young man far younger than himself, who had won the public's love in an absurdly short time and become his most troublesome obstacle.

Jin Taekyung.

The name lingered in his mouth, accompanied by a faint pain at his throat.

Swish.

Michael carefully pulled down the turtleneck that covered his neck. A dark-red mark stood out against his skin, warped by a brief surge of heat.

It was the first wound he had suffered in more than a decade. He was tracing the mark Jin Taekyung had left several days ago when—

Bzzzt.

A phone vibrated somewhere. His fingertips trembled against the wound, which had yet to heal.

Instinctively, Michael pulled his collar back up and looked at the name on his smartphone screen.

[Emmanuel]

There were many people in the world named Emmanuel. But only one could contact him directly without going through Huginn.

Click.

"Congratulations, Guild Master."

The President of France's voice came through the moment the call connected. Michael laughed aloud and tipped all three cups of coffee onto the floor.

Out went his anxiety and agitation, along with the face that had appeared in the hazy steam.

Once he had poured it all away, nothing remained in the empty cups but joy and triumph.

I… won.

The throne was ready. All that remained was a magnificent coronation.

Michael found himself wondering what expression Jin Taekyung wore now that he had heard the news.

The scene came so vividly to mind that his lips twitched.

It was strange.

Something that should never have happened had come to pass, yet I felt oddly calm.

Probably because I'd seen it coming.

"Fuck."

Still, I had to do what needed to be done. It wasn't like I could shout, *Yay!*

Having cursed out of habit, I looked at Team Leader Choi, who had just come through the door.

"So… we couldn't stop it?"

Team Leader Choi nodded gravely.

"There was only so much we could do."

"Even with Russia helping us? Russia, of all countries?"

"Even if the United Kingdom had joined us instead of remaining neutral at this General Assembly, I doubt the result would have changed much. We're already effectively at war."

Even someone as clueless about politics as I was knew how much power the permanent members of the Security Council held. I also knew that the "international situation" the experts went on about on TV was, in the end, a power game between nations.

This world was another Murim.

Martial artists flaunted their families and martial arts. Great powers showed off their militaries, economies, production capacity, and other resources, then used that power to crush weaker countries.

At this UN General Assembly, five permanent members—among the most powerful countries in the world—had joined forces to oppose the reestablishment of the World Hunter Federation.

Ordinarily, plenty of countries under their influence would have fallen in line like appendages, whether they liked it or not.

Ordinarily.

“More than twenty countries, including Congo, Syria, Ethiopia, and Myanmar, are on the verge of civil war,” Team Leader Choi said. “Coup factions are rising in the name of public sentiment. Those countries must have wanted a decision as soon as possible. The others aren’t in much better shape.”

“Damn it.”

“Fear is breaking down the rule of law. This is what Michael Silbert wanted.”

Politics had nothing to do with it anymore. This was about survival.

If several big, powerful men blocked the fire hydrant while your house was about to burn to ashes and told you to wait just a little longer, who would obediently turn around and leave?

I understood where those countries were coming from.

But…

Finding out the fire extinguisher is actually a flamethrower is another matter.

I had to admit it.

The World Hunter Federation was absolutely necessary.

During the last Great Cataclysm, when terrible flames had spread in every direction, they had played the role of excellent firefighters. They had done their best as heroes more devoted than anyone else.

But Michael Silbert was no firefighter.

What could be a greater black comedy than the person who had secretly started the fire being appointed as the new firefighter?

That was why, three days ago, I had told everyone we had to stop him. Within the time we had been given, we had to use every ounce of our strength to hold Michael Silbert back.

Now the sand in the hourglass we had turned over was almost gone.

After just three days.

“This… isn’t this too soon?”

Team Leader Choi and I weren’t alone in the room.

The Skeleton King’s words came out like a groan. He clenched the papers in his hand, crumpling them badly. Between his fingers, I could see a familiar face printed on one of the sheets: a man looking into the camera, younger than he was now, his expression more human.

Michael Silbert.

Michael Silbert several decades ago, to be precise.

For the past three days, we had been digging through everything brought back from Siegfried Bassmann's hideout and investigating Michael's past, searching for anything that might help us stop him.

But Michael Silbert was one of the most famous people in the world. Decades of information had piled up since the Great Cataclysm. There was too much of it, and time wasn't waiting for us.

"Can't we stop him?"

I had no answer for the Skeleton King.

Magic Johnson, who had been put in charge of the material from the hideout, might have discovered something by now, but the possibility was slim.

Even when he had come to us by hologram three days earlier, he had already gone over all the material more than ten times—and then gone over it again.

All I had left was a guess bordering on despair.

"Yeah. Probably not."

"…!"

"So far, all we've done is confirm what everyone already knows."

A heavy silence settled over the room.

The Skeleton King stared at the mountains of paperwork, his eyes trembling. Then he spoke.

"No. There is still a way."

"There's… a way?"

"A very simple one. No need to take the long way around."

What he said next was the last thing I expected.

"Wicked human, you need only erase this body."

"What?"

At first, I thought I'd misheard him.

But as I stared at him, the Skeleton King continued calmly.

"Not right away, of course. Reveal my identity in front of everyone, with important people watching, and then erase me. That will make the effect certain."

"…!"

"It is a simple solution, is it not? If you have been caught by a weakness so serious that you have no choice but to comply with his demands, then eliminate the weakness. Along with a suitable explanation."

A chill ran down my spine. Every hair on my body stood on end.

He stood before me as he always did, yet he had never felt more like a stranger.

His deeply sunken gaze. His faint smile. Even his calm voice.

Every part of him.

“This body is a monster. To you humans, I am practically evil itself, and I am also cunning enough to deceive the eyes of insignificant humans and approach them whenever I wish.”

The Skeleton King grinned.

“You, human—I confess that you are not nearly as wicked as I have called you. You are merely absurdly strong and even more stupid. The other humans know that too. If you show them with your actions, they should have little trouble believing you.”

Thump. Thump. Thump.

My heart hammered.

Thoughts tore through my head. My mouth had fallen open, but I couldn’t force a sound out.

This is fucking insane…

I had never once considered it. That made it all the more shocking.

Then, as I froze for an instant, a voice pierced my ears like a needle.

“It is a possibility.”

“Team Leader Choi!”

My shout burst out instinctively, but Team Leader Choi did not flinch in the slightest.

His face rigid, he continued.

“A weakness is only a weakness when it’s exposed and an enemy can use it. If you remove it yourself, there’s no problem.”

“What the hell are you talking about right now…”

“The public still loves you, Mr. Jin Taekyung. Although the extermination of the terrorist group brought about the appearance of The Prophet, it was done for the sake of a greater good, and you gave everything you had to save people despite the countless accusations thrown at you. In particular, the self-sacrifice you showed against Leviathan and during the Monster Wave in Munich…”

“Enough!”

My second shout finally stopped him.

But not for long.

“Then what are you going to do?”

“…!”

“Is there another way? A way to stop Michael Silbert from taking the World Hunter Federation—the entire world—into his hands?”

I couldn’t breathe.

With me at a loss for words, Team Leader Choi let everything he’d been holding back pour out.

“We could hide the Skeleton King somewhere far away, somewhere no one knows, or somewhere no one could ever find him. But if Michael Silbert revealed the truth, would people believe it?”

“But he…”

“Yes, I know. He’s saved many people. He fought beside us in Sichuan, Busan, Japan, and Munich. Perhaps hundreds of thousands of people owe him their lives. But—”

Thud.

Team Leader Choi stepped forward hard, bringing his face close to mine. His eyes held a tangle of emotions, and his voice was firm.

“People don’t believe it.”

His last words dwindled like a dying campfire.

“Because the Skeleton King… is a monster.”

Chapter 770

“Because the Skeleton King… is a monster.”

Silence followed as Team Leader Choi’s voice faded. But his last words kept echoing in someone’s ears.

A monster… A monster, huh.

The Skeleton King turned the bitter truth over in his mind.

It was true. He was a monster.

Monsters were humanity’s greatest and worst enemy in all of history. And among them, he wielded the cursed power of death.

He might look human now, but once the Magic shrouding his body fell away, all that would remain was the skeleton of a dead man who had defied his mortal fate.

That was the only truth.

Yes. That’s all there is.

The Skeleton King looked down at his hands, indistinguishable from a human’s, then raised his head.

Before him stood a young human with a familiar face, though his expression was so twisted he almost looked like a stranger.

The strongest being the Skeleton King had ever seen. Foolish, too, and therefore unable to accept the truth before his eyes.

But if they were to take the only way out, they had to accept that truth and use it.

“That human is right. It is all true.”

“…You.”

So many emotions filled Jin Taekyung’s strained voice. A few months ago, the Skeleton King would not have known what to call them. Now he did.

He shook his head at Jin, who could say no more.

“No matter what you say, this is the only way.”

“…!”

“This body is a monster. Whatever the reason, we cannot be allowed to remain together.”

Of course, some might understand even after the truth came out. They might trust Jin Taekyung and accept that the Skeleton King was different from the monsters they knew.

But…

“How many of them do you think would truly accept this truth?”

The Skeleton King pointed toward the closed window.

Most of the humans out there were ordinary people. They could hardly help hating monsters to the bone. Monsters had taken their families, their friends, or the people they loved.

Monsters killed humans, and humans killed monsters.

The chain forged with the descent of the Demon King Asmodeus was too thick and strong for anyone to break.

Not even a young hero loved by everyone was exempt. No—if everything came to light, he could no longer be the hero he had been.

“Many will condemn you, and Michael Silbert will get everything. So…”

His voice trailed off. Turning away from Jin Taekyung, the Skeleton King put a hand on the doorknob and added one last thing.

“Erase this body in front of everyone.”

Click.

The door closed behind him.

The Skeleton King crossed the hallway in silence without looking back. The lights overhead were bright, but the path before him was dark.

Like that place filled with thick fog and the energy of death.

Like the Gate he had been unable to leave from the moment he first opened his eyes—until one unexpected day, a human had taken him away.

What am I? What’s my name? My past? My homeland?

He thought he finally knew the answer to the questions that had come to haunt him.

He was a monster.

A cruel, savage monster without a trace of reason.

A being born of pure evil, incapable of living alongside humans.

That was the truth. No—it had to be the truth.

Faced with a reality he had no choice but to accept, the Skeleton King gave a hollow laugh.

Damn it. I’ll never be able to go to a club again.

And yet, for some reason, part of him felt relieved.

He was a monster without a heart, incapable of even ordinary emotions.

He was supposed to be.

You didn’t need anyone to tell you. Living day to day taught you soon enough: life was a series of choices.

They weren’t all grand ones. Small decisions started the moment you opened your eyes in the morning.

Get up or stay in bed? If I get up, take a shower? Or just wash my face and hair before heading out?

It depended on the situation. If you woke earlier than expected, you could sleep a little longer. If you were worried about being late, you could skip the shower.

What mattered was considering the result before you chose.

Because you were the one who had to live with it.

And right now, I stood at a crossroads where I could barely bear either choice.

“You… fucking lunatic.”

I barely managed to force the words out.

I might have been cursing the one who had left, or the other person still in the room.

Or maybe myself, unable to go one way or the other.

“Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

My tangled thoughts made my head throb. At the quiet voice in my ear, I closed my eyes without a word.

“You must choose.”

It felt like an invisible awl had gone straight through my skull. Every word made the headache worse.

“He has already chosen his path. A sacrifice that only he could decide to make…”

I grabbed him. Thud!

I didn’t know when I’d opened my eyes, much less how I’d ended up gripping Team Leader Choi by the collar.

Riiip.

The collar of his crumpled designer shirt tore under the force of my grip. Above my whitening knuckles, a pair of eyes silently gazed at me.

“Do as you wish. Beat me to a pulp. Break my limbs, or even kill me. But…”

His breath trembled. So did his voice.

“Afterward, you must choose. You must.”

“…!”

“You know time won’t wait for us.”

His words, his gaze—the strength went out of me all at once.

The energy boiling through my entire body as if it were about to explode, the hand clenched with all its strength—everything felt strangely unfamiliar.

I stumbled back as if I’d come to my senses after being possessed.

“…I’m sorry.”

I knew Team Leader Choi had done nothing wrong. Everything he had said was true. It was simply the only solution capable of breaking through this situation.

If the Skeleton King hadn’t offered it himself, Team Leader Choi would never have said a word.

That was who he was.

His cool judgment had shown him the only solution, but he had the decency not to force that sacrifice on someone else.

Some might call him a hypocrite. I wouldn’t. I knew the Skeleton King wasn’t just another monster to be killed and disposed of to him, any more than he was to me.

Even if he were the one who had to sacrifice himself, he would have offered it as the solution before anyone else.

Unlike me, Team Leader Choi was a born leader.

If the choice had been his instead of mine, he wouldn’t have run from it. He might have suffered alone, but he wouldn’t have turned away from the truth like a coward.

Damn it.

Time wouldn’t wait for us.

At the thought of his words, another world waiting for me beyond this one flashed before my eyes.

Murim.

If the Main Quest hadn’t blocked the Login function, if I could spend far longer thinking about this there, what would I choose?

No. Given enough time, would I even be able to choose?

And could I live with the result?

I’d fought countless battles. I’d struggled to survive and fought to protect my people.

But both paths before me ended in pain.

If I refused to sacrifice the Skeleton King, this world would fall into Michael Silbert’s hands. If I did sacrifice him… I didn’t think I could bear it.

Somewhere along the way, the Skeleton King had become my friend.

A comrade I’d fought beside. A friend.

Not someone I could sacrifice for the sake of the greater good.

I’d have to erase him. Do it myself, in front of everyone.

A cheap trick like using the Inventory to fake his Erasure wouldn’t work. Michael Silbert wasn’t that careless.

Proving I had complete control over the Skeleton King wouldn’t change anything, either.

To humanity, monsters were a raw nerve no one could touch. Hadn’t decades of experiments already shown that monsters could never be tamed?

The Skeleton King was unprecedented. But some truths were rejected the moment they became known.

In the end… there's only one answer.

I closed my eyes. Countless thoughts flashed through my mind, and then I spoke.

"Team Leader Choi."

He had been waiting in silence for my decision.

"Go ahead."

"Is there any chance the approval to reestablish the World Hunter Federation could be revoked?"

"Why do you suddenly—"

"Just answer me."

I opened my eyes. Team Leader Choi studied me with a conflicted look before replying.

"There is no chance of that."

"You're sure?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"The World Hunter Federation is now indispensable. Given the current situation, with magical power levels rising every day, it is the only way to stop a spark that has already been lit from spreading."

"Even if something happens to me or that bastard?"

"…!"

His eyes shook violently. A moment later, he understood what I meant and shouted.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung!"

But I had already chosen.

Neither the first path nor the second. A third one, dark and choked with thorns.

I would kill Michael Silbert, the man at the center of it all.

"No!"

"Nothing's impossible. It's just difficult."

I answered calmly and kept going before he could interrupt.

"If I pull this off… you'll need to make your move, Team Leader Choi. Magic Johnson will do everything he can to help."

"Stop! Stop talking!"

"There's Chuck Hagel, Faye Chen, and Prince Felix too. Get the support of the S-rank Hunters you've built ties with and the nations friendly to us. Then take control of the reestablished World Hunter Federation."

"I don't want to hear it! And how could I possibly…?"

"Your maternal grandfather walked that path. If you can make people understand the weight of Cheon Taemin's name, you have a shot. If that seems impossible, you could back Magic Johnson instead."

I grinned.

"Well, you're smart enough to figure it out yourself."

"…!"

"Still, one more thing, just in case. Even if Michael Silbert loses his head, the rest of his organization will remain. You should find those people and get rid of them first—"

Shing.

A cold sound cut me off.

A sword stood in my way.

Team Leader Choi had drawn the *Hero's Sword* without my noticing. He glared at me, his face set.

"You're not going."

"Hmm. I don't think you can stop me."

"Nothing's impossible. It's just difficult."

He threw my words back at me. I stepped toward him.

"Fine. I was going to rough you up anyway. This works out."

"What do you mean?"

"Everyone knows we're close. If I beat you half to a pulp before I leave, it might keep them from getting suspicious."

"…!"

"…!"

Team Leader Choi gritted his teeth. A dazzling aura flared around him, its immense power rippling along the blade and stirring the air.

Rumble. Whoooosh!

A tremor spread through the entire building. The wind rose into a gale.

"You really do have talent. You've improved a lot."

I gave him a calm smile and was about to step forward when—

Bzzzt.

A faint vibration sounded from somewhere, cutting through the tension between us.

Chapter 771

Bzzzt.

It wasn't hard to identify the vibration. I had something in my own pocket that made a similar sound.

"Team Leader Choi, looks like you're getting a call. Aren't you going to answer?"

"Don't worry about it. That isn't what matters right now."

"What, afraid I'll jump you while you're on the phone?"

"That…"

Team Leader Choi trailed off.

The fact that we were facing off at all was absurd. No matter how gifted he was or how quickly he'd improved, he couldn't stop me.

The only reason he was still on his feet was that I was letting him stay there. I was holding back for a friend I had no choice but to bring down.

And I had another reason to hold back.

"If someone's calling your direct line, it must be important. Go ahead and answer. I need to wait for enough witnesses to gather anyway."

"Witnesses…?"

"Yes. Witnesses."

I watched Team Leader Choi turn the word over in his mind, then went on.

"The more people who see what happens next, the better. For all of us."

There was no other way.

Team Leader Choi and I had been in the same boat for a long time. If I killed Michael Silbert, he'd be implicated as my accomplice. And it wouldn't stop with him. The Peace Guild, the Ares Guild, my family and friends—everyone connected to me would be hurt.

That would be the end of everything.

To prevent the worst, I have to draw a line between us where plenty of people can see it.

Soon, I'd be a criminal as notorious as The Prophet, if not more so.

A traitor to humanity who, when a longtime comrade confronted him about joining forces with an undead monster, struck him down without hesitation and fled with the monster.

And… the murderer who killed Michael Silbert, the hero of the age, in broad daylight.

"A couple of broken bones won't be the end of it. While you're taking the call, check that you have a potion ready."

Team Leader Choi bit his lip.

"…You're serious."

"I've thought it through. I know which road I'm taking."

At some point, I'd gained too many things to protect. Every choice demanded that I think it through, then think it through again.

But once I'd decided, I had to cast hesitation aside. The moment I looked back, I'd hesitate. I'd leave an opening.

Little by little, I'd learned not to look back.

In Murim. In the modern world.

Among monsters that came charging at me to kill me, and loathsome people even worse than the monsters.

"This is the path I chose. Right now, it's the best one."

Sacrifice the Skeleton King, or hand the world to Michael Silbert.

I couldn't choose either. So I'd made a different decision.

Rather than let Michael control me like a puppet, I would kill a hero and become a traitor who had joined forces with a monster.

Even if that was what it took, I would tear out the root of this disaster.

He dies by my hand today.

Whoosh.

A scorching heat spread throughout my body. Spitting out a single word as though I were chewing it to pieces, I unleashed the qi wave I had drawn up to its limit in every direction.

Rumble!

A violent tremor shook not just the building, but the surrounding area.

The force dwarfed anything Team Leader Choi had released. The hologram television, which had been playing silently, crackled and shut off. Alarms throughout the building began to wail.

Beep, beep! Weeeee!

"What the hell is—ah!"

"Aaaah!"

"Emergency! This is an emergency! Everyone, please evacuate!"

The murmurs that Team Leader Choi's earlier tremor had stirred up turned to screams.

Amid the countless footsteps passing outside the door and the desperate shouts they were vomiting out, Team Leader Choi, who had been staring at me with a hollow expression, suddenly raised the *Hero's Sword*.

Thunk!

The silver blade plunged into the floor, slicing through it like tofu. He squeezed his eyes shut, then opened them and pulled a smartphone and a potion from inside his clothes as though he had resigned himself to everything.

Then I saw his eyes widen. A moment later, his fingers flew across the screen.

Flash.

A huge man appeared in midair amid the glow of a hologram. Magic Johnson looked more frantic than I'd ever seen him.

"Damn it. Why are you taking so long to answer? Did you look at the materials I sent? I found something strange a little while ago—wait, what the hell is going on here?"

He looked from Team Leader Choi to me. I didn't answer. I strode toward him.

More precisely, toward the documents in his hand.

This is…

Several photographs. Pages packed with tiny text.

My eyes were sharp enough to take in every detail in barely a dozen seconds. As I read, possibilities I'd never considered began to take shape.

Why the hell would this…? Wait. If that's true…

One thought led to another, tangling with the rest. A pale fog filled my mind, and I groped for whatever lay hidden inside it.

"Ah."

The sound escaped my lips. The energy roiling inside me, ready to explode, began to settle.

Fwoosh.

My qi wave dispersed, and the tremors slowly died away.

But my gaze wavered more than ever, as did my mind after glimpsing the true shape of something beyond the fog filling my head.

If this is true…

Yes. If it really was…

Unable to finish the thought, I stared blankly at Magic Johnson. Then I turned to Team Leader Choi—and to the *Hero's Sword* planted in the floor before him like Excalibur.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes?"

"Why did you pull your sword out all of a sudden? You scared me."

"What?"

"I need to think. Put it away and calm everyone down. It's really loud out there."

"…What?"

What the hell? Is he insane?

Reading the thought plainly conveyed through Team Leader Choi's eyes, I let out a hollow laugh.

No matter how people around us looked at me, I continued to quietly chuckle to myself like a madman for quite some time before suddenly slapping both cheeks hard.

Smack!

Maybe a little too hard.

The full-force slap rattled my skull, but it brought my mind back from its brief AWOL stint before it got beyond the garrison limits.

All right.

Finally back in the room, I looked at the two men's bewildered faces and spoke.

"All right, everyone. Now let's all…"

Good breathing. Good emotion.

Deliver the last part solemnly.

"Let's carve out a fourth path where every last fucking bastard dies and we survive."

Team Leader Choi's and Magic Johnson's eyes twitched at my grand, solemn declaration.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung…"

"Hey, Jin…"

What more needed to be said?

I gave a faint smile and nodded as though I understood everything.

The new hope I'd glimpsed at the last moment had lit a heat somewhere inside me, different from Scorching Yang Qi. It kept welling up.

No. It was overflowing.

Drip. Splash!

"…What the fuck?"

Was it really going to overflow?

Heat—or rather, a torrent of red liquid—gushed from my nostrils, which had opened up with refreshing force before the fourth path even had a chance to do so. The two men's gazes went cold.

"You have a nosebleed. A really bad one."

"It reminds me of the fountain in the plaza of my mansion. More precisely, it looks like the baby angel built into the fountain is pissing like that."

"You should have slapped yourself more gently."

"He's going to pass out from blood loss at this rate. Choi, do you have a potion?"

"I took one out just now. I didn't expect to use it for this…"

"Good. Give it to Jin. And what did you mean by a fourth path? No, never mind. Stop the nosebleed first, then explain."

"Here, take it. And step back a little, please. You're spraying blood."

"…"

As I accepted the potion from Team Leader Choi, I thought that going straight to fight Michael Silbert might have looked a lot cooler than this.

But this was me.

A man who might look anything but cool right now, who might make a damn fool of himself, but would still struggle for the best outcome he could get.

A realistic man busting his ass for the sake of this world where no one could see him, the true man of this era who was—

"What are you doing? Swallow it. All in one gulp."

"Jin, do you have trouble taking potions? Want me to help?"

Team Leader Choi was nagging me like a mother-in-law. Magic Johnson had started licking his lips for some reason. I looked at them in alarm, then hurriedly emptied the potion into my mouth.

Ssshhh.

Ice-cold healing energy coursed through me. The tremors stopped as if they'd never happened, and the hologram television came back on.

A familiar face filled the screen.

Gray hair. Gray eyes.

The man looked as though he had been born somewhere between light and darkness. He stood before countless camera flashes and cameras, continuing to speak without sound. Stark subtitles ran beneath him.

> **Live:** UN Emergency General Assembly Approves Reestablishment of World Hunter Federation by Overwhelming Vote
>
> **Michael Silbert:** I offer my wholehearted praise for the UN's decision on behalf of humanity, and propose an inaugural ceremony for the newly reestablished World Hunter Federation.

"Turn off mute!"

Beep.

At Team Leader Choi's urgent command, the sound trapped in the speakers rushed out like a flood.

"Does that statement mean that you intend to become the representative of the World Hunter Federation yourself?"

"Michael! Can an inaugural ceremony really be held in a situation like this?"

"When and where would you like it to be held?"

"We're from the *Washington Post*. Please give us a statement!"

The questions came like screams.

So many reporters surrounded Michael Silbert that the cameras couldn’t fit them all in. He answered none of them, merely waving a hand with a grave expression.

Swish.

He was a hologram. In reality, he had to be several kilometers[3136] away at the very least. Yet it all felt vivid.

The air around him. The sense that the entire scene had been arranged for him alone.

The presence of that man, radiating suffocating majesty simply by being seen and heard.

Only Michael Silbert was free to speak there now.

“I swear to God, I proposed the reestablishment of the World Hunter Federation three days ago for one reason alone: for this world, for humanity.”

“…!”

I could feel it. The tumult wrapping around them.

And there he stood beneath a spotlight brighter than any he’d known in his life: a born agitator and orator.

“The representative of the World Hunter Federation should go to someone other than me. A living savior, the hero of the Great Cataclysm who already saved humanity from the Demon King once before!”

His voice, infused with internal energy, carried on and on. Overcome with excitement, people looked to the sky and cried out.

Sky. Slayer. Cheon Taemin.

Many names for one man. But a considerable number of people were chanting another name, too.

Michael Silbert.

As the fervor spread like fire, he pressed on.

“The inaugural ceremony will be held without fail. Whether it is the mad terrorist who calls himself The Prophet, any monster whatsoever, or even the return of the Demon King, the Hunters of the World Hunter Federation will gather in one place, choose their representative, and swear that they have become humanity’s sword and shield!”

“Waaaaah!”

My ears rang. I could hear the roar now without the speakers.

Through the cracks around the tightly shut door, I heard the whole city shouting as one.

No. Perhaps it was happening all over the world.

Everywhere light reached and electricity flowed.

[3136] One kilometer is about 0.62 miles.

All those people cheering for the hero shining alone at the center of it, without the faintest idea that he was behind everything.

As the fervor swelled beyond anything the crowd could contain, Michael Silbert spoke with more force in his eyes and voice than ever before.

To the people caught up in it. To the cameras trained on him.

Or perhaps…

“Two days from now. Seoul, Korea.”

Toward me—the one who could do nothing but watch him from here.

Michael Silbert made his declaration to the world.

“In the savior’s homeland, where the World Hunter Federation first began, we will rise once more, just as we did then.”

Chapter 772

The incitement, the speech, the declaration—it was over.

But the enormous roar did not end. It continued without pause.

Reporters' cameras caught the crowds pouring into the streets, while their microphones picked up cheers shouted in half-hoarse voices. Everywhere felt like a festival.

Only days ago, disaster had descended on this city. Now an inexplicable hope and joy filled it. Those feelings gathered and flowed toward one man.

"Michael! Michael!"

They chanted his name and applauded with all they had.

For a very long time. With all their strength.

They poured out their gratitude and respect for a true hero who had stepped forward for their sake, without the slightest desire for the immense power of the World Hunter Federation.

Their hero stood on the stage and gazed at them, his face full of emotion. Then, unable to hold back his tears, he turned and hurried away.

The retreating figure of a hero who had always seemed so strong was beautiful.

From behind.

"You've arrived."

Huginn was waiting below the stage. He gave a slight bow and gestured, and the Odin Guild's Hunters hurried to block the reporters following Michael.

"Please step back."

"Just a moment. It'll only take—"

"I'm sorry, but not today."

As Michael walked on, the bright lights and the cheers gradually faded behind him. He wiped the tears from the corners of his eyes and spoke in a dry voice.

"They responded well. Better than I expected."

"They needed hope that badly. And those tears at the end—you were magnificent."

"Did you think I was acting?"

Huginn slowed at the unexpected question.

"You… meant them?"

"I did. Though I'm not sure I felt what they did."

Tears were strange things. They came with joy, sadness, anger—even emotions the person shedding them could not easily name.

His tears had been closest to that last kind.

What was it?

Joy at finally reaching his grand objective?

Or… a few of the fragments of feeling he had left?

Michael Silbert thought about the reason for his tears, which even he did not know, but soon shook his head inwardly.

He did not always need to find the right answer.

If he had tried to find the right answer to every problem he had faced, he would not be standing here now.

No. He would have died decades ago.

On that day.

“Guild Master?”

Huginn’s voice broke into his thoughts.

“Go on.”

“I have something to report. Just before you began your speech…”

“The small disturbance on the outskirts of the city?”

“You’ve already received a report?”

“No. I sensed it, faintly.”

Huginn, who had been following behind him, stopped short. Michael Silbert smiled faintly.

“Surprised?”

“To be honest, yes.”

“I thought you might be.”

The disturbance had been considerable, but it had happened several kilometers[3137] away. Michael recalled the sensation that had swept over him.

“It surprised me too. Heat reached me from all that way off, so suddenly it felt as though every hair on my body might stand on end. For an instant, it was as if I could look down over the entire city.”

“…Guild Master, could it be—”

“I know what you’re thinking, but I wouldn’t worry. I only felt it that intensely for a moment.”

Michael muttered, almost to himself, “Perhaps I’ve been training too hard.”

“You should stop training for a while.”

“I’ve already been holding back. I did push myself too hard this past year. Perhaps I grew impatient without realizing it.”

He already knew what had made him impatient.

As well as the identity of the intense heat he had suddenly felt in the distance just before beginning his speech.

“What happened to Jin Taekyung? If it had been an emergency, you would have interrupted me in the middle of the speech. It can’t have been too serious.”

[3137] One kilometer is about 0.62 mi; several kilometers is a few miles.

"According to the watchers, the Stone-King left the hotel first. Not long afterward, the area shook."

"The top floor where they're staying must have been the source."

"Yes. Then everything went quiet, as if nothing had happened."

"The monster left first. What else?"

"They tried various types of magic after approaching as closely as possible, but both the view inside and even the sounds were blocked, so…"

"That's enough. I'd expect as much."

Michael fell into thought. Then he murmured, "It seems they've had a disagreement."

"A disagreement?"

"They must differ on what to do. And judging by what Jin Taekyung has shown us, he may do something even more reckless than we expect."

"If you mean *that* reckless, surely…"

"What else? He doesn't have many options in this situation."

Huginn's eyes widened. Michael continued.

"Increase security and strengthen the surveillance network until the inaugural ceremony. In particular, don't take your eyes off that monster for even a moment. He is the most important key to this entire affair—he cannot be left out of it."

"Understood."

Huginn answered grimly, then asked, "Wouldn't it be better to use this opportunity to capture the monster alive?"

"Capture him?"

"Yes. If they hide him, or reveal his identity and sacrifice him before we can…"

"Huginn."

Michael cut him off gently and looked at his right-hand man.

"I told you before that Jin Taekyung has a more fatal weakness than anyone else. Do you remember what it is?"

"His emotions…?"

"Exactly. And that is why he has no choice but to hold on to the monster until the very end."

"You mean…"

"Yes. Somewhere along the way, Jin Taekyung began to think of the monster as a friend."

"…!"

"Funny, isn't it?"

Michael could not suppress a quiet laugh.

Even though he was remembered as one of the heroes of the Great Cataclysm, there had been plenty of walls in his way. Back then, he had not been

overwhelmingly powerful, and the Odin Guild could hardly have been called a major guild.

So he had become stronger. He had brought down the walls and rivals before him by any means necessary.

But it was truly laughable.

And now? He had built a force and fighting strength no one could ignore, only to find that the obstacle in his path was the softest-hearted bastard he had ever faced.

Idiot.

Michael gave a hollow laugh and kept walking.

By then, his security team—no, his personal guard—had surrounded him on every side, each Hunter giving off a sharp aura.

Step after step, dozens of feet sounded as one.

When they reached the building where he was staying, the escorting Hunters spread out like a fan to secure the area. Their cordon was so tight that no one could break through.

Huginn stood at their head and gave a slight bow. Michael nodded to him without a word, then stepped into a space reserved for him alone.

Click. Whooom.

The moment he entered the room, the lock engaged. Dozens of defensive and security spells activated in succession.

The distant cheers he had still been able to hear seconds ago cut off.

At last, perfect silence.

Instead of settling onto the sofa, Michael crossed the broad carpet to a large full-length mirror covered in black cloth. He pulled the cloth away and channeled his energy into the clear glass.

Hummm.

A fine resonance filled the room. The mirror’s flawless surface rippled, distorting everything within it.

Whoosh.

The spacious room changed. So did the furniture and fixtures scattered around it. Finally, the person changed too.

In an instant, the scene in the mirror became one of utter darkness. A figure wrapped in a thick robe waited there for Michael Silbert.

“A very moving speech.”

The voice gave away neither age nor gender.

As The Prophet’s lips curled slightly beneath the robe, Michael Silbert’s eyes sank deep.

Winter nights are long.

That night felt especially long because most of the world could not sleep.

“The World Hunter Federation will protect humanity!”

Michael Silbert.

The declaration of a hero who had proven himself over decades set the public’s hearts ablaze again, just as his words had three days earlier.

People rushed into the streets, cheering and shouting. Fireworks burst over cities, and countless people sang as they marched through them.

All they had needed was a little hope.

Hope that someone would protect them and their loved ones from that monster. The hope that humanity would win again this time, just as it had in the past.

Michael Silbert’s declaration washed away the fear that had gripped them for three days, then spread to every corner of the world.

> **Nigerian Civil War Ends!** “We only wanted answers.”
> **Congo: Protesters Halt March on Presidential Palace**
> **French President:** “The protesters have dispersed. The peace we have now was possible because a hero gave the UN an answer.”

Strictly speaking, all of this had begun with a single word from Michael Silbert, but the public saw him differently.

> ㄴMichael did it all. He’s a true hero. ㄴExactly. If he hadn’t stepped forward, how long would it have taken to reestablish the World Hunter Federation? At least a month. ㄴFuck. A month? Those UN bastards would’ve dragged it out for a year. My family and I would be dead by then. ㄴWhat the hell are the other Hunters doing? Why did Michael have to handle everything himself? ㄴShooting commercials. ㄴCalm down. The other Hunters are doing their best too. Praise Michael all you want, but don’t put them down for it. ㄴYou sound just like my mother. Is your name Masa? ㄴHonestly, I’ve been a little disappointed watching this unfold. Especially in Sky and Jin. ㄴHmm. Same. ㄴWhat are those two doing right now? Everyone I know loves them, me included, but… I don’t get it. Jin even swore at Michael three days ago. ㄴI read that Jin’s showing symptoms of PTSD. You can at least cut him some slack for that. ㄴFine. I get it. What about Sky? ㄴEven the President of the United States probably wants to know. He hasn’t appeared in ages. ㄴI know one thing about him. He saved my parents. ㄴYeah, we all know that.

> Where is he now, and what's he doing? ㄴ You'll find out soon, so shut your fucking mouth. The inaugural ceremony is tomorrow. Are you whining like a little brat because you can't wait even one more day?

Hope. Joy. Questions. Anticipation.

Those countless emotions mixed and merged as the inaugural ceremony of the World Hunter Federation drew closer by the second, and prominent Hunters and Guild Masters from countries all over the world boarded private planes bound for Korea.

Of course, I was one of them.

Chapter 773

It was good to have somewhere to return to. Better still if there were people waiting for me there.

“Team Leader Choi! Taekyung!”

After several hours of flying, we arrived at Incheon Airport. From far away, a hairy giant came thundering toward us with both arms spread wide.

Whump!

The air caught in my throat.

Even as Im Kkeokjeong squeezed us in a hug that felt more like a chokehold, Team Leader Choi and I patted his shoulders while he sobbed.

It just felt like the thing to do.

“Why are you crying? Hit menopause already?”

“You’ve been okay—waaah! You’re not hurt anywhere—waaaah!”

“We’re fine. Please calm down.”

“I was so worried, so worried—sniff!”

Going by appearances, even the Green Forest Alliance Leader would have to step aside for him. But when it came to being sensitive, no one could match him.

The man’s outside and inside couldn’t have been more different.

And from over Im Kkeokjeong’s shoulder came a voice as clear and direct as the impression its owner gave.

“You should say *we* were worried, not *I*. What does that make me when you put it like that?”

Song Song stopped and looked Team Leader Choi and me over carefully.

“Hmm. You both look better than I expected.”

I asked in return,

“Are you sure? I’ll be suffocated in five minutes at this rate.”

“That’s five minutes from now. You look fine at the moment.”

“Can’t you see how bloodshot my eyes are? I haven’t slept properly in three days.”

“Why? You look much better than you did on TV a few days ago.”

She added, “Your eyes were completely gone then. You looked like you were about to drop dead.”

“…And now?”

“Hard to say. Like you might die in a hundred years or so?”

I couldn’t think of an answer, so I grinned.

Song Song was right. My body was exhausted, but my mind was incomparably clearer than it had been a few days ago.

Team Leader Choi’s was, too.

“How did the matter I asked you to handle go?” he asked.

“I delivered your instructions properly—to both the Peace and Ares Guilds. Once I narrowed the list down, there weren’t even ten people. But the ones I chose are all staunch loyalists.”

“Is there any chance the information leaked?”

“I picked only the most trustworthy senior members of the two Guilds. All their families are in Korea, too.”

“Well done. I’ll give the instructions myself from here on, so please make sure everything stays confidential, Miss Song.”

She nodded, then spoke cautiously. “But is Michael Silbert really…?”

“Shh.”

Looking perfectly composed, as though he hadn’t been sobbing a moment ago, Im Kkeokjeong cut her off. He whispered just loud enough for us to hear.

“He’s coming.”

He was right.

Several limousines glided across the quiet runway and stopped in front of us. President Baek Hanseong stepped out of one of them, looking as though he’d aged ten years since we last saw him.

“Welcome home, both of you.”

His voice sounded as worn out as his face.

A weekday afternoon.

The airport would normally have been packed. Instead, it was quiet inside, and outside was no different.

Police officers and soldiers appeared everywhere in the scenery passing beyond the limousine window. Here and there, people in black suits wore earpieces and, of course, Blue House badges on their chests.

“It’s nice and quiet,” I said.

“As you requested, we cleared everyone out in advance for security.”

Baek Hanseong continued as he threw away the red ginseng juice he had finished drinking.

“Of course, it was a necessary precaution with that terrorist out there.”

He meant The Prophet.

Only a few hours earlier, he told us, a huge crowd of reporters and well-wishers had surrounded the area.

“This may not be something I should say as President,” he muttered, “but lately, everyone seems to have lost their minds. Things are getting far too extreme.”

I agreed with him. I understood the crowds, too.

People who had no power to protect themselves were bound to go to extremes in a crisis. One moment they trembled as though humanity would be wiped out tomorrow; the next, the word *hope* made them blindly devoted.

…That's what he was counting on.

"Pardon?"

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

Baek Hanseong seemed to sense something in my unthinking mutter. A complicated expression crossed his face, but I turned back to the window without another word.

He had helped us a great deal already. Depending on what happened next, he might be able to help us even more.

I couldn't tell him everything—not because I distrusted him, but because I couldn't trust what surrounded him.

There are plenty of ways.

Michael Silbert's eyes and ears were everywhere.

There could be a mole among Baek Hanseong's closest advisers, and there was every chance he was being watched.

The moment anyone was confronted with an unbelievable truth, they were bound to be shaken.

Being an experienced politician did not mean he could hide every emotion. If the enemy noticed something because of that, the situation would become even more disadvantageous.

And we can't rule out the possibility that the clue we found isn't the truth.

My eyes met Team Leader Choi's, and I could tell he was thinking the same thing.

He had limited his instructions to a tiny handful of the most trustworthy senior members of the Peace and Ares Guilds. Those instructions had been delivered covertly, and even they had nothing to do with the truth we'd uncovered.

They were only a safeguard for a worst-case scenario—a way to act before the grenade's pin was pulled, or to contain the blast if it went off.

For now, though, we couldn't be certain of anything.

Less than twenty-four hours remained before the inaugural ceremony. How it ended would decide everyone's fate.

Michael Silbert and me.

Beyond the simple divide between the enemy and us, it would decide where the world went from here.

Vroooom.

While my thoughts tangled themselves up, our limousine raced down the open road. Baek Hanseong filled us in on the latest news: the international situation, the

decision to hold the inaugural ceremony at the National Assembly, and the list of participants confirmed so far.

He even told me how my mother and Hayeon were doing under heavy security.

"Your family has heard the news, and they're very worried. If you'd like, we could take you to them right now…"

I understood what his trailing words meant and shook my head.

"No. I'm planning to see them after the inaugural ceremony."

"Are you sure that will be all right?"

"Of course."

I missed my family more than anyone in the world, but I couldn't see them like this.

No. I mustn't.

I was afraid I'd lose my composure if I did.

Once everything was over, I wanted to face my mother and Hayeon with a peaceful mind. I wanted to rest in their warm embrace.

…If I can.

The words I couldn't bring myself to say lingered on the tip of my tongue, then faded. Just then, Baek Hanseong asked as though something had occurred to him.

"Where is the other person, by the way?"

"Ah."

"I'm fairly certain he was on the list of people entering the country… Has something happened?"

I hesitated, then met Team Leader Choi's eyes. I gave a bitter smile.

"He'll be late. Something came up."

It was a lie.

The Skeleton King was with us right now. He was simply keeping an endless silence inside a mysterious space no one else could see or sense.

Even now.

How long are you going to stay holed up in there?

This time, too, there was no answer.

That day, the whole world's attention was fixed on a small peninsula in East Asia.

The usual laughing, chattering variety shows were nowhere to be found on television. News channels, current-affairs programs, and internet forums were all abuzz over the World Hunter Federation's first inaugural ceremony, now less than a day away.

> ㄴWho's coming to the inaugural ceremony? ㄴNo idea. They flat-out said they wouldn't release the list because of the terrorist threat. Cleared out the airport, too. ㄴHeard they aren't broadcasting it live, either. They'll record it, though, so I guess we'll find out after it's over. ㄴWhy keep the list secret? If they're that worried about terrorism, why not hold a video conference like they did at the UN? ㄴFact: They showed up in person even during the Great Cataclysm. ㄴIt's a declaration that they won't back down, no matter what. Everyone's been fighting separately until now. Once the Federation is established, The Prophet is fucked. ㄴCheon Taemin's the most likely representative, right? ㄴYeah. Who else but Lord Taemin? ㄴMichael Silbert. ㄴJin Taekyung. ㄴI like Lord Fuck, but he doesn't measure up to Michael Silbert. Michael's got the seniority, and what he's done lately has been huge. ㄴDoesn't matter. It's Cheon Taemin either way. ㄴTrue. ㄴMaybe it's because Cheon Taemin hasn't shown up in so long, but I'm getting a chill. Just me? ㄴThen turn on the boiler.

The questions kept coming. Who would attend? Once they were all together, whom would they choose to represent them?

As the hours crept by, guests who had crossed thousands—even tens of thousands—of kilometers[3138] began arriving on the peninsula.

"We'll need to conduct a brief identity check."

The young man had neatly styled brown hair and faintly green eyes. He looked as though he'd stepped out of a fairy tale, and when he spoke, his voice carried an air of authority.

"I am Felix Alexander Louis, Duke of Cambridge, Earl of Strathearn, Baron Carrickfergus, Knight of the Order of the Garter, and Knight of the Order of the Chain."

"Pardon?"

"Those titles are merely for show. Feel free to address me casually."

"Ah, of course. Then, Mr. Felix…"

"Feel free to call me His Highness Prince Felix Alexander Louis. Casually."

"…Yes."

Prince Felix had just finished the brief scan when a large shadow fell over him.

"It's been a while, Felix. Oh, should I call you His Highness?"

At the familiar face looking down at him from far above, Prince Felix seemed about to frown, but then relaxed his expression.

He would have scolded anyone else. But this was one of the few people from whom he could tolerate a little rudeness.

[3138] One kilometer is about 0.62 miles; 1,000 km is about 620 mi, and 10,000 km is about 6,200 mi.

"Mr. Johnson."

Magic Johnson smiled faintly.

"Just get here?"

"I did."

"Faye Chen will be here soon, too. All of us who fought together in China will be in one place."

"So it seems. And who is the gentleman behind you?"

"He's with me. Though he's no gentleman."

Felix had never met the middle-aged man in person, but he recognized him at once. He was as huge as Magic Johnson, dressed like he'd stepped straight out of the American frontier, and had a cigar between his lips.

"…Chuck Hagel."

Chuck Hagel, who had been puffing away at his cigar in front of a no-smoking sign, answered,

"You calling me, Prince?"

At his irritable tone, Magic Johnson eased forward. "Since we've run into each other, how about a drink? Faye Chen can join us."

Felix studied them both for a moment, then shook his head.

"I have no interest."

"Too bad."

"See you tomorrow. Both of you."

"Sure. Then we'll do that."

A perfectly ordinary exchange.

Felix gave them a brief nod and walked off with his attendants. Under tight security, he reached his assigned lodgings, unpacked, and went to bed early ahead of the next day's ceremony.

Or so everyone thought.

But…

Click.

The locked door opened. The lights came on.

Felix had slipped out of his lodgings unseen. Now he could make out the figures who had been waiting for him in the dark—and the young man seated among them.

"It's been a while, Your Highness."

Felix gave a quiet laugh.

Choi Minwoo laughed with him. So did Magic Johnson, Chuck Hagel, and Faye Chen.

Their night, known to no one else, deepened.

Chapter 774

Back when I was a rookie Hunter, I used to cry sometimes.

No—if I'm being honest, pretty often.

Looking back, I suppose it was all growing pains. But that was how it was back then.

It was only natural. I had barely reached adulthood, and the Hunter Training Center was just that: a training center.

What was my first real fight like?

No matter how hard I try to remember, it's hazy as fog. Not because the memory has faded with age, but because I half-lost my mind the moment the battle began.

A few fragments remain clear.

The backs of the tanks as they buckled under the sheer number of monsters. The thick stench of blood and the reek of creatures that didn't belong to this world.

The spear feeling heavier than it ever had before. Sweat pooling in my grip…

That was all. The moment we clashed, everything around me seemed to recede. When I came to, there was blood everywhere.

The Team Leader had been waiting for me to wake up, a cigarette between his lips. The first thing he said was:

"You. Rookie."

"Y-Yes."

"You fucking bastard."

"Excuse me?"

"I almost died saving your ass. Did my wife put you up to it? Tell you to kill me so you two could split the insurance payout?"

"N-No."

"You fought pretty well for someone who'd lost his mind, but pull that shit again and you're going to die. Seriously."

"…I'm sorry."

"By the way, what's your name?"

"Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung, sir."

"What year were you born?"

"2020."

"Fuck. People were still being born in 2020?"

The Team Leader glared at me, puffing hard on his cigarette. Only then did he tell me his name.

"I'm Hong Cheonsu."

"Oh. Yes, sir."

"From now on, when we're off duty, call me… Uncle? No, that's a bit much. Call me hyung.[3139] Cheonsu hyung."

"Yes, Cheonsu hyung."

"This kid doesn't even pretend to refuse. And we're still inside the Gate, you little shit."

I didn't know it then.

I didn't know that I'd come to stick with that foul-tempered Team Leader like a brother through thick and thin. Or that, only a few years later, he would sacrifice himself for me.

"You did good. Here's your payout."

Six 50,000-won bills,[3140] after taxes and the Guild's fee.

I took my pay for risking my life that day and went back to my goshiwon.[3141]

When I opened the door, the room—less than four pyeong[3142]—smelled of mold. A family photograph sat on a table with a chipped corner.

And I cried.

At first, I sobbed quietly. Before long, I had buried my face between my knees and was bawling like a child.

If someone hadn't opened the locked door, I might have kept the entire goshiwon awake all night.

"Hey, new guy. Sorry for barging in without asking. I'm the manager here, but the complaints kept coming, so I had to use the master key…"

The manager took one look at my tear-streaked face and trailed off. He scratched his greasy hair, then closed the door.

He looked like some middle-aged guy, and I figured he wouldn't be back.

A little later, he returned with soju[3143] in one hand and a bag of ramen in the other.

"Want a drink? Oh, wait. You're not a minor… Obviously not. Look at the size of you. Whew."

Memories from nearly ten years ago.

Time passed, and I changed. My fear of monsters and the loneliness of being away from my family gradually faded.

No. I grew numb to them.

Like a hamster on a wheel, I just kept running.

Even if I wasn't getting anywhere, running was better than stopping. There were things I could protect only by keeping that wheel turning.

[3139] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[3140] Each 50,000-won bill is worth about $36 or €32. The six bills total 300,000 won, about $210 or €190.

[3141] A *goshiwon* is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent housing arrangement, often used by students and people with limited means.

[3142] One *pyeong* is about 3.31 m^2 or 35.6 ft^2; four pyeong is about 13.2 m^2 or 142 ft^2.

[3143] *Soju* is a Korean distilled alcoholic drink.

Family. Friends. Comrades.

I couldn’t stop anymore.

At some point, the little wheel in the cage that held me had become the enormous wheel of fate. And the word *duty*, which I carried in my heart, had grown clearer and heavier.

Maybe that was why.

Why I had been able to revisit that fading memory, if only in a dream.

Why my cheeks were wet when I opened my eyes to someone shaking me awake.

“…kyung. Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

I blinked. My blurred vision finally came into focus.

A familiar face looked down at me with concern. His expression had barely changed, which only made the small trace of emotion stand out more.

“Are you all right?”

I rubbed my wet eyes and answered.

“I don’t know.”

“Did you have a bad dream?”

“I’m not sure.”

I sat up, my voice hoarse. The clock showed that it was just past noon. Through a gap in the curtains, I could see how dark it was outside.

“I don’t know if it was a bad dream or a good one. I really don’t.”

Team Leader Choi watched me in silence before speaking calmly.

“Don’t dwell on it. It was only a dream.”

He was right. A dream was only a dream. Whether today brought good or bad fortune was up to us—and deciding that was my role.

No. It was everyone’s.

“I’m still half-asleep, so let me ask you something. Was last night a dream too?”

“Last night?”

“Yeah. There were a lot of familiar faces. Toward the end, I even saw a British prince dressed as a hotel bellboy.”

Only then did a faint smile touch Team Leader Choi’s lips.

“How strange. I had the same dream.”

“Oh, you did? Personally, I thought it was a pretty good one.”

“So did I.”

That part, of course, hadn’t been a dream.

Our secret conversation had gone on until the small hours of the morning. Worn out by the past few days, I’d fallen asleep as if I’d passed out.

Maybe that was why my mind felt clear and my body felt light.

Almost too light.

There is one small problem, of course.

I focused on the faint pain deep inside me.

Broken Body still hadn't healed. Its effects weren't just numbers displayed by the System. Like a parasite clinging to a host, it was eating away at some of my strength.

Can I do it? Even like this?

The question flashed through my mind. I shook my head.

Whether I could do it wasn't the question.

I had to.

For me, for my people, and for everyone else.

"Are we ready?"

Team Leader Choi answered without hesitation.

"Everything is ready."

There was certainty in his voice—the kind that came from having done everything he could to prepare.

But I asked again, this time addressing someone else, crouched somewhere out of sight.

"And you?"

Once again, there was no answer.

He must have seen and heard everything, but he chose silence again. As though he were trying to cut away every last shred of affection between us. As though he were a traveler packed and ready to leave.

But… I had no intention of letting him go.

Especially not for a reason as fucked up as this.

"Let's go."

I said it evenly and left the room. Team Leader Choi followed at once, and the Hunters of the Peace Guild and Ares Guild filled the corridor behind us, trailing like a dragon's tail.

It was time to set the enormous wheel in motion.

The sky was gray that day.

Dark clouds had spread across the capital region before dawn, bringing a light drizzle. The air felt chilly against the skin.

But the weather meant nothing to the people.

They expected the clouds to clear and the sun to shine through soon.

No. *Certainty* might have been a better word.

The historic inaugural ceremony of the new World Hunter Federation.

That was the sunlight they had been waiting for: an alliance of superhumans who would save them from the second Great War, soon to descend on them—or perhaps already begun.

Heroes of the past, present, and future would gather in one place and become Hunters in the truest sense. They would be humanity's sword and shield, drive away the dark clouds, and protect the world from the monsters surging in like waves.

Today.

Here.

New history begins.

Michael Silbert ran his fingertips across the table.

The enormous round table had three hundred seats. Marks left by sharp weapons covered its surface.

The marks the heroes left behind.

He remembered that day clearly.

When the World Hunter Federation—an alliance unlike any before it—was born, Michael Silbert had been there to share in its glory.

Beside those now long dead, he had shouted with his blood aflame. They had drawn their weapons and pointed them skyward, then driven their swords into the great round table and sworn to become humanity's sword and shield.

Yes. Right here.

He could never forget it.

Michael Silbert gently stroked the chair he had once occupied. Age had left it rough and creaking, yet even that stirred something in him.

But that was all.

He looked down at the chair that held those memories without sitting in it or leaning against it. His gaze drifted away from it, toward the center of the round table.

The only empty space.

There was no chair or platform there. Ringed by three hundred seats, it almost looked as desolate as an uninhabited island.

But neither Michael nor anyone else had thought so back then.

One man had always filled that space.

Stronger and brighter than anyone else. A hero among heroes, whom even those who envied him could only regard with awe and fear.

Sky.

Michael Silbert raised his head and looked around.

The First National Assembly Hall had since become a World Heritage site. Stained glass installed just after the war, depicting humanity's victory in the Great Cataclysm, glittered on every side.

Humans and monsters locked in fierce battle. Blood flowing in rivers. Corpses piled everywhere…

His gaze passed over the old heroes immortalized there by their dazzling feats, most of them now dead. Then it settled on the highest point in that glorious record.

Two figures set into the ceiling.

Well. You're still looking down at me from up there.

Michael Silbert gave a quiet laugh.

The savior who had driven his sword into the heart of Asmodeus—the Demon King who had cast humanity into a pit of fire—looked down at him.

As though warning Michael not to forget him.

As though he might descend at any moment and mete out divine punishment.

But…

Not anymore, Sky.

Michael Silbert smiled softly.

In his youth, he had been neither particularly strong nor particularly weak beside the other heroes. Now he had returned, his strength beyond anyone's denial.

And what about you?

Cheon Taemin—the man Michael had revered and feared, the man who had forced him to lie low for fear of attracting his notice—was gone.

All he could do now was remain as a record in this place and watch Michael, who would soon ascend the throne.

"I'll take the place where you once stood."

The words came out full of elation.

Grrrnnng.

The tightly shut door opened. Light spilled through the gap, along with a voice.

"What a load of bullshit. What a load of bullshit."

Chapter 775

Every now and then, what I really think slips out before I can stop it.

Like right now.

“What a load of bullshit. What a load of bullshit.”

Michael Silbert showed no reaction to my tone. Instead, he greeted me with the last traces of elation still on his face.

“You’re earlier than I expected. I’ve been waiting.”

“Practicing your musical all by yourself?”

“Musical?”

He considered that for a moment, then gave a short laugh.

“I suppose that isn’t wrong. What happens here today is a musical of sorts. One man directing, staging, and starring in the whole thing.”

“My mother used to say that if you eat whatever’s put in front of you, sooner or later you’ll make yourself sick.”

“No need to worry. Nothing will go wrong, and the show is guaranteed to be a hit.”

“That line you delivered just now was pretty awful. You sure it’ll be a hit?”

“It was only a rehearsal before the main performance, but I’ll take your opinion into account.”

The easy manner. The faint smile on his lips.

As he came closer, my stomach twisted. Each breath felt like a huge needle stirring around inside it.

*Was this the effect of **Broken Body**? Or was it because I was standing face-to-face with the lunatic now right in front of me?*

Maybe both.

“Did that friend come with you?”

“Find out for yourself.”

“Not a bad idea.”

Michael gazed at the firmly shut door over my shoulder, then nodded.

“I’ve confirmed it. You brought him here safely.”

An ordinary civilian watching us might have wondered what the hell he meant. I didn’t.

Sss…

There was no sound. No visible shape.

But I felt it: the wave of qi he had sent out, slipping back into his body the instant it found what he was looking for.

He did it with a natural, practiced ease more like a Supreme Peak master of Murim than a Hunter. He was unlike any ordinary Hunter I'd met. Worse, even I couldn't gauge how strong he truly was. He still hadn't shown his full strength.

But I couldn't let him see that anything was amiss.

A brief silence fell between us. I broke it.

"He came with me."

"Hmm?"

"I didn't bring him. We came together."

Michael looked puzzled for a moment, then laughed aloud.

"Very well. If the person involved insists on putting it that way, perhaps there is a difference. But what possible difference could it make?"

"A hell of a difference. Someone like you wouldn't understand, even if you died and came back."

"No. What matters is that you and your friend are here. And if anything matters more than that…"

The voice reaching my ears suddenly dropped into a low murmur.

"Your intention."

"My intention?"

"Yes. Your intentions today."

He watched me as though he'd suspected them from the start. I let the silence sit for a moment, then spoke.

"Let me ask you something."

"I'm the one who should hear an answer first, but very well. I'll permit the question."

"What are *your* intentions?"

"What?"

"Why commit all these atrocities? What could you possibly want badly enough to sacrifice so many people and push the whole world into a pit of fire?"

Step.

I closed the few paces between us until our noses nearly touched. I could see the smallest change in his expression, the fine hairs on his skin. I could feel his breath.

Human.

Considering everything he had done, it was difficult to believe, but Michael Silbert was undeniably human, just like me.

Blood, flesh, and bone.

So why?

"Why did you do it? What the hell was it all for?"

Ever since I'd first met him, all I'd felt toward Michael was anger. Not now.

I genuinely wanted to know. I couldn't understand him. The more clues I found about him, the more questions I had.

"Born on March 18, 1994, in Paris's Tenth Arrondissement. His father ran away before he was born, and his alcoholic single mother, who lived with him, died in 2012."

What I'd learned of one man's life spilled from my mouth.

I turned away from Michael Silbert and began to walk.

Step. Step.

One step, then another. As I crossed the First National Assembly Hall, now a World Heritage site, I retraced his past.

A polite, diligent child despite a difficult home life. Then, after his mother's death, a late turn toward delinquency and several criminal convictions.

Finally came the event that changed his life completely.

"In 2020, when the Great Cataclysm began, he awakened in his mid-twenties."

I stopped.

I raised my head. In the stained glass set into the wall, a young man stood alone amid countless heaps of corpses, tears running down his face.

December 25, 2020 — The Great Battle of Paris

They said it had been one of the ten fiercest battles of the entire Great Cataclysm.

Instead of bells ringing through the streets to celebrate Christmas, screams and thunderous explosions echoed through Paris. A thousand Hunters stationed in the city waged an urban battle against monsters that outnumbered them dozens of times over.

For a whole week.

Without reinforcements. A desperate fight in every sense.

When seven days and nights had passed and the last sun of 2020 had set, reinforcements arrived after finishing another battle. They found countless bodies, pools of blood, and one young man standing among them.

"That was you."

I turned slowly.

The face of the young man in the stained glass was there—the young man who had survived alone in that ruin, more than thirty years ago, while the stench of blood hung thick in the air.

"Michael Silbert."

He had listened without a word. At my quiet call, he finally spoke.

"I'll give you credit for the effort. You must have worked hard. The records from before my awakening were erased. They couldn't have been easy to find."

"You erased them. Having a criminal record wouldn't have done your reputation any favors."

“I won’t deny it. I thought it might stand in my way one day. Everyone was in chaos then, so it was easy enough to deal with.”

Michael Silbert answered calmly, then stared at me.

“But… if that’s all you found, I’m a little disappointed.”

“What?”

“The Tenth Arrondissement, where I was born, was a shithole. Fights broke out several times a day. Gunshots rang out every night. The alley wall I passed on my way to and from school was always dark red. Nobody cleaned the blood off. It would only be red again the next day.”

“…”

“That was my hometown. By day, gangs of every race roamed the streets. By night, neon signs lit up the entertainment district. You called my mother an alcoholic, didn’t you?”

He answered his own question without a change in tone.

“Apparently you didn’t know she was addicted to drugs, too. Whenever I came home from school, she’d be sprawled across that worn-out sofa with men I’d never seen before.”

Everyone had a painful past. Yet as Michael recalled his, a faint smile touched his lips.

“A man who planted his seed and ran. A woman who was my mother only in the eyes of the law. And their child, whose life became a string of assaults and thefts. That was me. But I’m also the hero who saved Paris twice, and the pioneer who was first to speak up for people in danger.”

“…!”

“I used to be ashamed of my past. Not anymore. From slum child to hero of the world. Excellent marketing, wouldn’t you say?”

I stared at him, at a loss for words.

What did someone have to go through to become so worn down? The clock that had run without stopping since the day he was born looked as though it had been ticking for six hundred years, not sixty.

His heart looked much the same.

Under my gaze, Michael’s smile widened.

“You’re looking at me as if I’m a monster. Are you afraid of me now, too?”

“Too?”

“Everyone who knows me looks at me with fear and respect. You aren’t the first.”

“Some of them are dead by now, I’m guessing.”

“If they won’t bow their heads on their own, shouldn’t they be forced to yield? They were fools.”

He wasn’t talking about enemies long gone. He was talking to me.

A warning to lower my head before he crushed me by any means necessary. A meticulous attempt to make sure not even the slightest possibility of things going wrong remained.

I studied him for a moment, then broke the silence.

"You're half wrong and half right."

"What do you mean?"

"It's true that I see you as a monster. But this isn't fear. It's pity. You could call it disgust, too."

"…!"

"I just wanted to ask. Whether this could be cleaned up before irreversible sacrifices occurred. Whether any trace of humanity remained in this lunatic. And…"

My voice sank.

"I'm a little disappointed. That you thought I could hold you back with nothing more than a few criminal convictions."

"What?"

Before he could make sense of it, I turned and held out my hand.

Whoosh. Bang!

Qi flowed from my fingertips and gently pushed the shut doors open. Beyond them, I could sense people drawing closer up the stairs.

I tipped my head toward Michael. His face had gone rigid.

"Don't keep busy people waiting. Start the inaugural ceremony you were so eager to hold, you fucking bastard."

"…!"

"You haven't even transferred the deed, and you're already acting like the landlord. What a fucking asshole."

I ignored his icy stare, sat in the nearest chair, and leaned back.

The die had been cast. It was still rolling, and soon we would see whether it came up one or six.

We'd find out who died and who survived, too.

And I had not the slightest intention of dying in a place like this.

Especially not at the hands of a monster instead of a human being.

Step. Step. Step.

Hundreds of footsteps finally entered the now-silent conference hall.

The first page in the history of the new World Hunter Federation was turning.

Chapter 776

Some questions in this world remain unanswered.

The relationship between troubled times and heroes is one of them.

Do heroes appear first, bringing troubled times in their wake?

Or do troubled times give rise to heroes?

Even after many years had passed, no clear answer had emerged that could satisfy everyone. But when faced with the history of the Great Cataclysm, even those who had argued for the former were forced to turn toward the latter.

A Great War unlike any other in human history.

The Great Cataclysm shattered everything people had thought they knew. It gave rise to countless heroes, then cast them into the jaws of death, leaving behind only their names and deeds.

But many heroes survived, too.

Heroes like those now gazing at the National Assembly Hall, filled with traces of glory, and the enormous round table at its center.

“Ah. This place hasn’t changed. Even the air feels the same as it did that day.”

“It’s changed a little. When did they put up that painting?”

“What are you talking about, hyung[3144]? It’s been almost thirty years. Weren’t you at the commemorative event?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“Because I never wanted to remember those days again.”

Power beyond that of ordinary humans did not preserve everyone’s youth.

An old man whose hair had turned white with the passing years murmured in a hoarse voice.

“So many empty seats.”

The survivors had carried losses as great as their glory.

Where were the comrades who had once sat around this table and cheered? The ones who had fought back-to-back against monsters surging in from every direction?

“I never thought I’d come back here…”

Yet fate had brought them back, as if playing a cruel joke.

Back to this place marked by glory and pain. Back to swear once more that they would be humanity’s sword and shield.

And new faces were filling the seats left empty by those who were gone.

[3144] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“Hello, Senior.”

“Who are you?”

“My name is Liam. We met during the Defense of Frankfurt, but I suppose you don’t remember me. Haha.”

“I’m sorry. I must be getting old if I can’t recognize someone I fought beside.”

“No, of course you wouldn’t recognize me. I was fifteen then.”

“Fifteen? Were you…?”

“Yes. I was one of the citizens in the bunker. You may not remember, Senior, but you saved my life back then.”

“Well, I’ll be.”

The great trees with sturdy roots were not the only ones to survive the typhoon.

Those who had once been saplings, weeds, or mere seeds had grown, too, and earned the right to sit at the round table.

But warm reunions like theirs were rare among the heroes of past and present. Humanity faced another grave crisis, and the heroes differed in both their values and the course they wanted to take.

Whom would they choose as their representative?

That was the most important question before them today. The older and younger heroes had naturally gathered with those who shared their views.

Two men stood at the center of it all.

Michael Silbert, renowned for his achievements and the first to call for the World Hunter Federation’s reestablishment.

And…

Jin Taekyung.

Michael Silbert repeated the name silently. He shook hands and exchanged greetings with the followers surrounding him, but his shadowed eyes remained fixed on the young man beyond their shoulders.

What exactly did you mean by that?

The voices flattering him seemed far away. All he could hear was what Jin had said moments earlier.

> “I’m a little disappointed. That you thought I could hold you back with nothing more than a few criminal convictions.”

The voice had faded, but the memory remained vivid. So did the shock Michael had felt at the time.

His heart, usually so calm, began to beat faster.

Wait. Could it be?

His gray eyes trembled as he watched Jin Taekyung.

Of all the possibilities he had considered, one had come to mind. It was the only way Jin could stop him now.

But… no. It couldn't be. It was absurd.

It's all but impossible for anyone else to notice. No, it's impossible.

Only one person could have done so: Cheon Taemin.

Even he, who had reached a one-of-a-kind realm, had merely sensed something in passing at the time. Michael Silbert, who had immediately noticed the warning sign, had been forced to lie low like a wanted criminal for a long time.

Until Cheon Taemin disappeared from the public eye.

Until Michael was certain Cheon Taemin's attention had shifted away from him.

And now Jin Taekyung, of all people? Not Sky?

As his unease grew, Michael shook his head inwardly.

No. Everything Jin had said was nothing but bravado.

Bravado meant to search for one final opening after everything was already over. The last desperate struggle of someone who had sensed his defeat.

But why?

Even as he dismissed it as a bluff, Jin's image rose before him like a haze, clouding his eyes and ears.

> "Then what is your intention?"

One question.

> "Why did you do those things? What in the world were you doing it for?"

Then another.

> "This isn't fear. It's pity. You could call it disgust, too."

That expression. Those eyes. That calm voice.

The young man had lived barely half as long as Michael, yet the emotion Michael had sensed in him was unmistakably close to genuine.

And if it was genuine…

Crack.

Bones shifted under the pressure of Michael's grip. A strained voice broke through his thoughts.

"G-Guild Master?"

"Hmm?"

"W-Why are you squeezing my hand…?"

"Ah."

Michael realized what he had done and loosened his grip.

The follower whose hand he had been shaking forced a smile through the pain.

"You certainly live up to your reputation. I used to be a tank, so I can hold my own when it comes to raw strength, but you're incredible, Guild Master."

The S-rank Hunters and heads of the great Guilds watching nearby were quick to agree.

"Of course he is."

"Haha. Odin Guild didn't become the best for nothing. Michael Silbert's name has been famous since the Great Cataclysm."

"Really, this was Paul's fault. I saw him squeeze first. Hahaha."

Laughter mingled with flattery disguised as praise.

Michael watched them, then felt a smile tug at his lips.

Yes. This was power.

This was why he had to gain authority by any means necessary.

The actions of the strong were always justified by the weak who feared their power.

It did not matter if they did not respect him. It did not matter if they did not love him.

If he could make them afraid—if he could reign over them rather than lead them—he would have everything.

Michael had first learned that truth in the back alleys of Paris's Tenth Arrondissement. He had seen gang members walk the streets with guns tucked into their waistbands, and people too frightened to report them. That was when he understood the path he had to take.

This is how the world works.

He gave his followers a gentle smile and turned his head.

Jin Taekyung was with the elders, many of whom had retired once already or still remembered Cheon Taemin's presence. Several other familiar faces were there, too.

Grand Mage Magic Johnson. Chuck Hagel, who had resigned as United States Secretary of Defense after the vigilante incident. Faye Chen of Hong Kong. Even Prince Felix of the United Kingdom.

They were formidable figures, even among the people gathered here from around the world. But their side held fewer than half of the three hundred seats.

The old generation must have come here looking only toward Sky, while the new generation followed Jin Taekyung.

But whom would they support once Cheon Taemin's condition became known?

His maternal grandson, whose only claim was their shared blood?

Or Jin Taekyung, absurdly young and so often reckless?

Even Magic Johnson, with all his achievements and popularity, fell short of Michael in fame and reputation.

Whether you wanted it or not, only one person remains.

Him.

The man who had harbored greater ambitions than anyone else and spent years preparing for this moment.

To Michael, the people across the table looked like sandcastles about to crumble.

Still… it pays to prepare for the unexpected.

He slipped a hand into his pocket.

The moment he pressed the pager inside, sending a signal to someone, his eyes met Jin Taekyung's.

A pair of reddish, heated eyes.

Michael felt the heat in them as keenly as a searing pain at the back of his neck, beneath his armor.

"…Hmm."

"Oh. What's wrong?"

"Mr. Silbert, are you feeling unwell?"

"I brought a potion just in case. Good thing I—"

"I'm fine. It's nothing. There's no need to fuss."

Michael answered firmly, then stared at Jin. Had Jin seen his reaction?

He fought down the unease.

But Jin was already looking elsewhere, and the sight of the figure seated beside him steadied Michael.

No—a monster in human form.

Stone-King.

As long as that creature was here, Michael would stand at the center of the round table.

He had to.

> —All attendees have arrived. Please take your seats.

The announcement came over the speakers. Michael clenched his fist.

The inaugural ceremony began, but the attendees did not fall silent.

If anything, their quiet whispers grew louder.

“All attendees have arrived?”

“That can’t be right. You must have misheard.”

“There must have been a minor mistake.”

The elders and the younger generation shared the same confusion. One person who surely had to attend was nowhere to be seen.

But after everyone took their seats, no correction came over the speakers.

Only then did they understand.

Cheon Taemin, humanity’s savior, would not appear.

Not today. Not tomorrow or the day after. Perhaps not before this second Great War came to an end.

“What in the world…?”

“Where is Sky? Where is that person?”

What everyone had taken for a simple mix-up set off a rising murmur, then shock and confusion.

And then—

Step. Step.

Someone rose from their seat and walked toward the center of the round table.

Chapter 777

So it's finally starting.

I muttered to myself as I watched the back of someone walking alone.

Then again, it wasn't just me. Everyone here was doing the same.

The cameras positioned throughout the room and some three hundred pairs of eyes around the round table followed Michael Silbert's every step.

Step. Step.

He walked without the slightest hesitation.

The murmuring had long since died away. As if by agreement, everyone had fallen silent, though they watched him with very different feelings.

Some couldn't hide their confusion at his sudden move. Others looked deep in thought. A few nodded as if this were only to be expected, or wore faint smiles.

I took them all in.

I caught every emotion that slipped across their faces, every slight movement at the corners of their mouths, and committed those faces to memory.

Then—

Swish.

Michael stopped just short of the center of the enormous round table. For decades, that place had belonged to one man alone.

His final step never came. It was as though something invisible stood in his way. He parted his lips.

"Everyone. Today, I received some deeply shocking news."

His voice was thick with emotion. Tears glimmered at the corners of his eyes beneath the lights.

He looked from the people unsettled by this unexpected turn to the cameras recording it, then continued.

"Just before the inaugural ceremony began, two young men came to see me and delivered the news. At first, I found it hard to believe. In the end, I had no choice but to accept it, and I needed time to compose myself."

"Could you tell us who those two young men were, and what news they brought?"

The question came at just the right moment.

Perfect timing. As if it had been planned.

No, it clearly had been.

In this scripted musical, the leading man delivered his next line in response to the bit player's perfectly placed question.

"There's no difficulty in telling you who came to see me. Both young men are well known, and both are here with us now. But I'm afraid I can't be the one to tell you what they said."

"Why not?"

"Because I'm not qualified to do so."

Michael answered calmly, then turned toward me—or, rather, toward Team Leader Choi, seated to my right.

"Unless you're family by blood, of course."

...!

Even the most oblivious person in the hall would have understood what he meant.

Hundreds of eyes converged on us. Amid them, a voice reached my ear in secret.

I don't know what you came here intending to do, but remember one thing from this moment on.

Michael Silbert was looking straight at me. The crocodile tears were gone from his eyes. Only ambition shone there now.

Every choice has consequences to match.

"..."

So choose carefully. You'll get only one chance, and you won't be able to take it back.

His final warning came with a stare. His eyes, and all the others fixed on us, felt so hot that I closed mine.

Yeah. So this is how it turns out.

From the very beginning...

There was no other way.

I opened my eyes, feeling hollowed out. Team Leader Choi met my gaze, read what was there, and rose from his seat.

Scrape.

The chair, which had endured for ages longer than its new master, slowly scraped backward. At that moment—

"Before we elect a representative—the purpose of today's inaugural ceremony—I must inform you that my maternal grandfather, Hunter Cheon Taemin..."

At last, his name was spoken. In the breathless silence that followed, the savior's only blood relative continued quietly.

"...has become seriously ill and will be unable to take part in this war."

...!

...!

An enormous, unseen shock swept through the hall.

A suffocating silence settled over the First National Assembly Hall.

Frozen by shock and confusion, the people inside could do nothing but turn those words over and over in their minds.

My maternal grandfather, Hunter Cheon Taemin, has become seriously ill and will be unable to take part in this war.

Barely ten minutes into the inaugural ceremony, a bomb had gone off.

No. In another sense, it was a catastrophe.

Sky is sick? What on earth does that mean?

How could he be? It can't be true.

The elders—the Hunters of the older generation—rejected the news most fiercely.

They remembered Cheon Taemin, the great hero who had saved humanity from the Demon King. The shock struck them harder than anyone.

It was only natural. In their memories, Cheon Taemin had been more than human, almost a living god.

They had seen him single-handedly destroy monster armies tens of thousands strong and tear the limbs from mighty S-rank monsters. His bearing had been as commanding as his strength.

With Cheon Taemin beside them, they had willingly marched into the jaws of death. Shoulder to shoulder, they had cut through wave after wave of monsters and kept advancing.

The elders could bear to remember those horrific battlefields because Cheon Taemin was part of those memories. Because those memories held the shining glory of having led humanity to victory alongside him.

And now he was ill?

The savior who had defeated even the Demon King Asmodeus was too ill to join the war?

Shock gave way to a hollow sense of loss. Some of the elders grew angry.

"What—what on earth is this supposed to mean?"

"Gravely ill? Even for someone like your maternal grandfather, that's too much to believe!"

"Explain yourself. There's no way he could be sick!"

But contrary to the elders' desperate wishes, Cheon Taemin's only maternal grandson merely shook his head, calm and composed.

"Everything I've told you is absolutely true."

"Young man!"

"I understand how you feel, Seniors. I felt the same way a few months ago."

"What… do you mean?"

"I always wondered where my grandfather was. What reason could he possibly have for not showing himself even to his only grandson, after all this time?"

Choi Minwoo looked around at everyone and continued.

“I didn’t learn the truth until after Vice Guild Master Lee Jungryong and Go Jun died. At some point, for reasons we still don’t know, my grandfather fell into a coma. A very small number of people had been hiding it.”

…!

Shock swept through the hall again. This time, the silence did not last.

“It’s hard to believe, but it’s true. I can vouch for it.”

A low voice had spoken up. A towering Black man, who had been watching the situation in silence, was looking at them.

“Magic Johnson!”

“Y-You knew too?”

Magic Johnson nodded before answering.

“Those young men contacted me a few months ago, and I came to this country. I didn’t expect to find Sky unconscious.”

“Th-Then it really is…”

“Yes. I drew on everything I know, every bit of Magic I could think of, and found no way to bring him back to consciousness. I couldn’t tell anyone else, either. If a secret like that got out, it would have caused even more chaos.”

People remembered what had been happening then. Magical power readings had begun to rise, and strange events had followed. In China, an Arch Lich had led a monster army through Sichuan, drenching it in blood. The public had grown more anxious by the day.

“But we can’t hide it any longer. The whole world is looking for Sky. Now that the World Hunter Federation has taken its first step, it has to give them the answer they want, just as the UN did.”

One word crossed everyone’s mind.

Leader.

With Cheon Taemin incapacitated, they needed a new leader somehow. A new hero who could fill the savior’s absence as much as possible. Someone who could win the support of a majority of the three hundred people gathered around this enormous round table.

Then…

By the time that thought formed, most had already made up their minds.

Strength. Fame. Popularity. A spirit of sacrifice and courage. Leadership…

Each had their own standards, and even among those already called heroes, only a handful met them.

One man in particular could not be overlooked.

Michael Silbert.

Countless eyes turned his way. Some people smiled triumphantly, as though the moment they had been waiting for had arrived. Others watched him, still weighing their decision.

Michael gave nothing away.

With only one step left to take, he was already thinking about what came after.

It's sooner than I expected, but… I need to get rid of him. As soon as possible.

The absolute power of the World Hunter Federation already felt close enough to touch. But an obstacle that would continue to trouble him had to be removed.

Michael Silbert fixed his sunken eyes on one man.

Even as voting began, Jin Taekyung sat with his lips firmly closed. Beside him was a blond monster with a calm expression.

I looked down at the scrap of iron in my hand.

What was it called again?

Ostracism? A pottery-shard lottery?

I thought it had originated with a method the ancient Athenians used to banish tyrants, but I wasn't sure.

One thing I did know: what I held wasn't a piece of pottery, but a fragment of a Tower Shield. And the person whose name appeared on the most fragments wouldn't be banished—they'd become the leader of the World Hunter Federation.

Would've been nice if it worked the other way around, huh?

I sent the Sound Transmission on a whim. To my surprise, an answer came back.

What the hell are you talking about all of a sudden?

Just saying. You're answering me this time, though.

Because this will probably be the last time.

I turned the scrap of iron over in my fingers.

You crazy bastard. I wondered why you'd answered me, but you're still on about that.

I know what you're thinking. But it's too…

Dangerous?

After a brief silence, the Skeleton King answered.

Yes. Even now, this body cannot be certain.

The odds are close to fifty-fifty. And this is just a guess, but I think the chance of success is a little higher.

Do you understand what that means? There's a fifty percent chance you could lose everything.

Really? To me, it sounds like there's a fifty percent chance I could protect everything.

…!

Trust me.

I looked around. Familiar faces. People I could trust, right beside me. Every one of them a comrade and a friend.

If you really can’t trust me, trust us.

This silence lasted longer than the first. Then, for the first time in a long while, I met the Skeleton King’s eyes.

Why go this far? Why take that risk when your family and friends could get hurt?

I answered with a truth that might have been settled the day I first met him.

Because you’re my friend, too.

Chapter 778

Because you're my friend, too.

At those quiet words, the Skeleton King's eyes trembled. I looked straight at him and continued.

That's all there is to it. You're my friend, too. If I lost you like this, I'd feel like shit for the rest of my life. That's why I can't give up.

…

Remember when we fought the Arch Lich in China?

The Skeleton King nodded silently.

Yeah. How could I forget?

That fierce battle was still etched vividly in my mind.

I really thought I was going to die. No—if things had kept going the way they were, I'd probably have died nine times out of ten.

It had been that hard a fight.

Countless monsters had blocked our path. And the Arch Lich we'd finally faced after killing Lee Jungryong and Wu Heixing, who had chosen to betray us, had been too much for me at the time.

But…

You saved me. Even knowing you might be erased.

I could still see him leaping out of my Inventory without even asking permission and taking the Arch Lich's strike in my place at that life-or-death moment.

It was a sacrifice.

A pure, noble sacrifice.

At the same time, it was a great deed that allowed an ordinary someone to finally become a new being.

And so the Skeleton Warlord who had ruled the Black Forest gained a crown.

He returned from the brink of Erasure, took up the radiant [Hero's Sword], and drove it into the Arch Lich's chest.

Why did you make that choice back then?

…Who knows. I don't.

The Skeleton King turned his gaze to empty space and muttered.

All I know is that I had a very stupid, very trivial reason.

A reason?

There was something I'd always wondered. Who am I? Where was I born, and what sin did I commit to become the monster I am now? Surely I wasn't always like this.

His hollow thoughts echoed in my ears.

But no matter how hard I tried, I couldn't remember my life before this. Even while living among humans, I was confused every moment I spent with them. I felt like something that was neither monster nor human. As though I were serving an endless sentence for a sin I'd committed in the past.

Yeah. Back then, that was how the Skeleton King had been.

He was always lost in thought, looking troubled. Sometimes he'd go into my Inventory and not say a word for days.

Then one day, I'd said something to him in passing.

I bet you were a pretty decent guy.

I didn't know for sure, but I was certain of it.

That was why. Maybe you'd only said it to comfort me, but I wanted to believe you. And part of me wanted to prove you right. If I really had been a decent guy in the past…

The Skeleton King slowly tilted his head. His gaze left the empty space and settled on me.

Then perhaps I could sacrifice myself for someone else… for a friend.

…!

Yes, that's right, you damn crafty human.

A faint smile touched the Skeleton King's lips.

You were the first friend this body made after coming into this world.

For a moment, I couldn't speak.

I had to say something. I should have, but not a single word came to mind.

So I just smiled.

I smiled silently at first, then let out a few quiet chuckles before I couldn't hold back any longer and burst out laughing.

Loud enough for everyone across the enormous round table to hear. Loud enough to draw hundreds of pairs of eyes toward us.

Then I looked at the Skeleton King, who was blinking in surprise, and said, "You only figured out something that simple now, you dumbass?"

C-Could you keep your voice down?

"Just say it out loud. Stop whispering so no one else can hear."

What the—

"It's too late anyway. Can't you see everyone's already staring?"

The Skeleton King looked around, then muttered in a half-resigned voice.

"Madman."

"What, madman? You finished?"

"I'm not finished. You attention-seeking bastard."

"Listen to the way this guy talks. Team Leader Choi, aren't you going to manage him?"

“Manage… what?”

Suddenly singled out, Team Leader Choi clenched his teeth, looking as if grim reality had just hit him.

“Yes, that’s right. I’m sorry. This is all my fault for failing to manage Jin Taekyung.”

“Come on, Team Leader. You’re going to hurt my feelings if you pile on, too.”

“I’m the one whose feelings are hurt. If things had gone according to plan, in a little while… No, why even make a plan if you’re going to do this?”

Fair enough.

But what could I do? Things had gone this way.

People’s affairs often took turns no one could predict. Just like right now.

Even so, I wasn’t the least bit uneasy about having done things out of order.

Yeah. That was good enough for me.

I burst out laughing again, then put on a deep, serious voice as I addressed Team Leader Choi.

“Team Leader Choi, haven’t you heard the saying, ‘It doesn’t matter how you get there as long as you get to Seoul’?”

“I don’t want to hear it. And we’re already in Seoul.”

“Come on, say it with me. Heave. Ho. Heave. Ho.”

“To hell with heaving and ho-ing. I think we’re royally fucked.”

“You’re acting all stubborn because you’re sulking, aren’t you? This was going to happen anyway.”

“The order is wrong! The order! Do you put the ramen in before the water boils?”

“No. Today I’m crushing it up and eating it without boiling it.”

“You motherfucking—!”

The man who could make Team Leader Choi swear like that.

That was me.

Just as Team Leader Choi’s eyes rolled back and he was about to spring to his feet, two enormous hands shot out from behind him and grabbed him.

Grab!

“Hey, Choi! Calm down!”

“Let go! You hear me? Get your hands off me right now!”

“Please, get a grip! I think Jin made a mistake, too, but… Wait. Have you been bulking up lately?”

This was a mess beyond all messes.

Seeing my chance, I gave Magic Johnson a thumbs-up as he felt Team Leader Choi’s lean muscles, then stood and looked around.

Open mouths. Faces asking what the hell was going on. Eyes gone unfocused.

A commotion had erupted out of nowhere at this important meeting to elect the World Hunter Federation's representative as humanity faced a crisis. Everyone looked as if they'd just seen Demon King Asmodeus brought back with Edo Tensei[3145].

Except for the few who already knew what was going on.

"Ah, I'm sorry. I wasn't planning to spring this on you yet."

It was a sincere, polite apology. But sometimes sincerity just didn't get through.

"You damn bastard. This might be the last cigar of my life."

Chuck Hagel pretended to answer with the bleak resignation of a terminal lung cancer patient, all while puffing on his cigar twice as fast.

"It's okay. I trust you. But go fuck yourself, Jin."

Faye Chen gave me a warm smile and raised her middle finger.

"I'm sorry, Your Majesty. I trusted that lunatic and made a rash choice…"

Prince Felix, third in line to the British throne, muttered with a look of regret.

But if I had to name the most bewildered person among the three hundred gathered here, it would be Michael Silbert.

What on earth… are you up to?

His voice crossed the space between us and reached my ear.

His face was stiffer than I'd ever seen it. I couldn't help laughing.

You're laughing?

It was only natural to answer someone who was curious.

I opened my mouth without a care.

"Yeah, I laughed. What are you going to do about it?"

You…!

The voice in my ear cut off. By now, everyone in the room was following my gaze, looking back and forth between Michael Silbert and me.

"If you have something to say, say it out loud so everyone can hear. You're too old to be whispering in my ear."

That sounded a little rude, so I shyly added one more thing.

"You motherfucker."

"…!"

"…!"

The room went silent, as if hundreds of nuclear missiles had swept through it. The air around us froze.

But unlike the others watching this unbelievable scene, I welcomed that cold air. It felt as if something blocking my throat and chest had finally cleared.

I can finally breathe.

[3145]Edo Tensei is a technique in *Naruto* that summons the dead back to life.

How long had it been since I'd felt this relieved?

I took a deep breath and started trudging along. I passed between the round tables, then got tired of even that after a few steps and leaped over everyone's heads.

Whoosh. Tap.

I landed lightly in the empty center of the round table.

Michael Silbert clenched his teeth. He stood there unable to set foot in that space, as though an invisible wall held him back.

"What… is this insolence?"

His voice was tightly restrained.

His eyes, fixed on me, held anger he couldn't hide. And I knew exactly why.

"What, you spent half your life wishing for that seat, and now some nobody gets there before you? That piss you off?"

"…!"

"Honestly, I understand. Something similar happened to me once. I'd saved some ice cream to eat after my bath, but when I came out, my little sister had eaten it all and left me the wrapper. I was pretty pissed. But…"

I trailed off, watching Michael Silbert's rigid face, then continued slowly.

"Then I suddenly thought, what am I getting so mad about over something this trivial? Is it really worth throwing a fit over?"

I looked around. Just as I'd expected, most people were staring at me like I was crazy.

Naturally. I'd caused a scene at the most important moment, hurled curses at a Senior, and now I was telling an ice cream story nobody had asked for.

Their expressions were so funny that I laughed again.

"Anyway, that's all."

At the same time, I drew up my internal energy and stamped my foot down hard.

"Don't—!"

Crack! Crunch!

Michael Silbert's belated shout vanished beneath the roar.

In the split second when nobody could stop me, I completely crushed the center of the round table, a place set aside for just one man. Then I looked at the faces staring at me in shock.

"After thinking about it, I realized that seat was just like that ice cream. If nobody was greedy, there'd be nothing to get angry about. But the greedy ones always step forward and cause trouble."

Of course, the difference between ice cream and the World Hunter Federation was beyond comparison.

Their importance in this world. And… the scale of what that greed had caused.

People had died because of that greed.

Hundreds of thousands of people had lost their families and friends, their homes and their hopes.

After paying such a high price, all they'd gained was despair and fear.

So what made that seat any different from the ice cream?

It was ridiculous. And it left me feeling hollow.

I spoke to the hundreds of people staring at me in shock.

"Everyone, listen."

No. I was speaking to Michael Silbert.

"The Stone-King is a monster."

That one casually tossed-out line swallowed everyone whole and exploded.

Chapter 779

For a moment, the world seemed to stop.

If not for the camera flashes blinking at regular intervals and the ticking of second hands, people might have thought time really had frozen.

But the silence didn't last long.

"He's crazy."

The words came from somewhere in the room.

Countless others looked back and forth between Jin Taekyung and the Stone-King, laughing in disbelief.

They couldn't help it. Everyone here knew who the Stone-King was.

No—ask anyone on the street, and they'd know, too.

An S-rank Hunter with United States citizenship who had appeared out of nowhere like a comet.

As skilled as he was handsome, he was always at Jin Taekyung's side. That had drawn attention from the start, and he'd distinguished himself in several major incidents.

He'd faced criticism alongside Jin for taking part in the operation against the terrorists in the so-called "vigilante incident." But most agreed that his contributions far outweighed anything held against him.

And now the Stone-King—a young hero of the new generation who had even earned a seat at the round table—was a monster?

Instead of confusion, disbelieving laughter spread through the room.

"Enough with the nonsense."

Speaking up once was hard. After that, it got easier.

Those who had held their tongues out of respect for Jin Taekyung's strength and standing began to raise their voices.

"Young man, we've let you go on long enough. Aren't you taking this too far?"

"Jin, I respect you as a fellow Hunter, but… you owe us a proper explanation for what you've done here today."

"They said he had post-traumatic stress disorder. Looks like it was true."

The fuse was burning down fast.

Even the elders who had looked favorably on Jin from the start murmured uneasily. Those who had already opposed him seized their chance and criticized him outright.

"Everyone, look at what he's done. He caused a disturbance while we were electing the leader of the Federation that will save humanity. He even damaged the round table."

"And now he's spouting nonsense."

“What kind of disrespect is this?”

Criticism poured in from every direction.

But Jin Taekyung, at the center of it all, addressed the room as though he hadn’t heard a word.

Once again.

Without changing a single word.

“The Stone-King is a monster.”

“That’s all you have to say? The same nonsense again?”

“He’s crazy. Completely crazy.”

Jin Taekyung slowly looked around.

Some laughed in disbelief. Some frowned. Others watched with grave, steady eyes.

Their reactions varied, but the words that came from Jin Taekyung’s mouth did not.

“The Stone-King is a monster.”

“What is this—!”

“Strip him of his qualifications at once!”

The criticism had become shouting. Jin paid it no mind and opened his mouth again.

“The Stone-King is…”

As if those were the only words he knew. As if imprinting that one fact on their minds were his sole purpose in life.

Without pause, ignoring every gaze and every accusation pouring toward him.

Calmly, he repeated the truth that might become his greatest weakness, looking straight at Michael Silbert—the one man who had remained silent through the uproar around the enormous round table.

“A monster.”

For the third time.

The mocking smiles faded as people watched him repeat the words like a machine.

The shouts stopped. So did the pointing fingers. No one moved or spoke.

Silence settled over the room.

And in that silence, too complete for even the sound of someone swallowing, a realization came to them.

Jin Taekyung was telling the truth.

His expression. His voice. His eyes. Nothing about him suggested a lie.

And they understood what that meant.

…No way.

The same impossible question crossed everyone’s mind.

At the same time, hundreds of pairs of eyes turned toward one person.

No—toward something that might not be a person at all.

The Stone-King.

The handsome American was still sitting where he had been all along. But they could see it. They could feel it.

The slight trembling of his eyes and the faint fear seeping through them. The certainty that this was the answer to their question.

Then the truth they had finally accepted came with an enormous unseen shock that swept through the room like a wave.

No. Like a hammer.

"…!"

"…!"

Everyone stared, mouths agape.

What was reflected now in roughly three hundred pairs of wide-open eyes was neither a handsome young man nor an S-rank Hunter with outstanding skills and Fame.

There stood a cursed being who could never coexist with humanity, one who had once driven mankind to the brink of disaster.

"…A monster."

Someone's mutter, almost a groan, broke the silence.

Clang, clang, clang!

Hundreds of weapons flashed beneath the lights of the vast hall.

The radiance of Aura—the power God had given humanity—spread in every direction before turning toward a single being.

With it came killing intent so palpable it seemed one could touch it.

Ssssss.

A wind whipped up from somewhere. In the freezing air, countless needle-sharp gazes pierced the Stone-King.

Everyone here had been chosen by God for the sole purpose of fighting monsters, and given the name Hunter by humanity.

From the beginning, they had had only one duty.

Kill monsters.

Whoooosh.

Hundreds of surging powers and killing intent joined, pressing down on the hall and bearing toward their target—

"Stop!"

Bang!

The shout roared like a wild beast. Its deep resonance found a gap in that split second and scattered everything like mist.

The faces of the people who had been ready to swing their weapons went rigid.

What the hell…

A place awash in killing intent and mana was as good as a death trap.

But the voice's owner had broken that flow. At the very last moment, just as an attack was about to be unleashed, he had slipped through an invisible gap.

And he'd done it with ease.

Step. Step.

The low thud of footsteps broke the suffocating silence.

As one young man cut through the mountain of sabers and forest of swords formed by countless weapons and stood in front of everyone, an elder Hunter with a full head of white hair spoke with a stern expression.

"What are you doing?"

Recognizing the elder, Jin Taekyung answered respectfully.

"I'm doing what I have to do, Senior."

"And what you have to do is… protect that monster?"

"I do."

At Jin's unhesitating reply, the elder Hunter asked with an expression of disbelief.

"Why?"

"Because he's my friend."

"…Your friend?"

"He's also a comrade-in-arms who saved my life. I have to protect him, just as he protected me."

Friend? Comrade-in-arms?

No one had imagined hearing those words used for a monster. While they struggled to respond, a voice rose from the encirclement that had formed around Jin.

"If you're going that far, there's no need to hear anything more."

A shining suit of full armor. A massive war hammer in his hand.

The middle-aged man stepped forward, radiating a weighty aura and an oppressive presence. His eyes were on Jin Taekyung, but he addressed the whole room.

"This is treason against humanity. An unforgivable betrayal. You know the punishment, don't you?"

Jin Taekyung nodded.

"Of course."

"Good. Then, as of this moment, your Hunter qualifications are revoked. The traitor will be executed on the spot."

Rumble.

A dense glow gathered in layers around the war hammer.

He was an S-rank Hunter who had fought since the Great Cataclysm, a man who had made the Kronos Guild one of the world's top ten Guilds.

But Jin Taekyung's response went far beyond anything the onlookers expected.

"Fuck, don't be so damn ridiculous."

"What?"

"That speech was so long-winded I couldn't even follow every stupid point. But first, I want to ask you one thing."

Jin Taekyung fixed a cold gaze on the Guild Master of the Kronos Guild.

"If you were going to throw this kind of fit, why did you treat me like a lunatic just now?"

"That's…"

"That's what?"

The Guild Master of the Kronos Guild fell silent.

So did everyone else who had heard the question.

Jin had struck a nerve.

They'd dismissed his words as nonsense from the start. Through all their criticism, he had quietly told them the same thing three times.

Until the smiles vanished. Until they realized it was true.

But why hadn't they believed him, when he'd meant every word?

The answer was simple.

Perhaps it was a truth they had known all along and could only pretend not to see.

"Let's be honest. Now that you know the truth, you don't want to accept it. That the guy sitting over there—a monster, of all things—has fought harder for humanity than some of the assholes here who have no business being at this table."

"…!"

"Though I get it, too. Who'd believe the Stone-King was a monster just because I said so? Right?"

No one answered. Jin Taekyung smiled.

"This is a black comedy if I've ever seen one. There are assholes everywhere who aren't even human, but the guy who nearly worked himself to death trying to save one more person is standing at death's door the moment his identity comes out."

Cold flames flickered in the young man's eyes, visible above his raised smile.

Countless weapons surrounded them. As he looked at that forest of blades, poised to come flying at any moment, the emotion rising inside him had a name: anger and bitterness.

"I didn't want this. I wasn't asking for much. I just… thought you'd give me enough time to explain."

Jin Taekyung's voice sounded hollow.

Of course he understood. Many of them must have lost people close to them to monsters.

He had, too.

But… even so, something churned inside him.

He felt sorry for the Skeleton King, who had fought while sacrificing himself for humanity. He felt bitter watching those people try to kill him without a moment's hesitation, and his anger rose when he realized how many of them still showed outright hostility, even in this situation.

Because he knew their hostility wasn't only about his calling the Skeleton King—a monster—his friend and comrade-in-arms.

He knew where that hostility was aimed, what it was meant to accomplish, and who stood behind those people, using them like puppets.

Step.

Jin Taekyung started forward.

The Guild Master of the Kronos Guild was the first to grasp what the movement meant. He moved to swing his war hammer like a bolt of lightning.

Or he would have, if a voice hadn't reached his ear.

"You'd better stop there, Fabian."

Rumble.

The air trembled.

The Guild Master of the Kronos Guild turned toward the towering Black man who had risen from his seat. His expression hardened.

"Johnson."

"Been a while. Age has made you even more charming."

Magic Johnson winked and gestured with his staff toward the war hammer rippling with Aura.

"Whoa. Don't do anything rash. Take it from a comrade-in-arms who's risked his life fighting beside you."

"Do you know what your actions mean right now?"

"Of course. You don't have to tell me. We know exactly where we're going from here."

"…We?"

Fabian repeated the word without thinking. Then he saw the answer for himself.

Rustle. Thud.

People rose from their seats—some quietly, some noisily, some with an air of dignity.

The Guild Master of the Kronos Guild's gaze darkened as he took in those familiar, distinguished faces.

Magic Johnson. Chuck Hagel. Faye Chen. Prince Felix.

And then Choi Minwoo, whose symbolic significance as Cheon Taemin's only blood relative was unmistakable. Finally, even the Stone-King, who had been watching the weapons aimed at him with a hard expression, stood up.

This is bad. It's already beyond the range Michael predicted.

But the greatest surprise was the young man who had reached him.

"Move."

"I can't—"

"I said move."

"…!"

For the first time in a long while, a chill sank into the Guild Master of the Kronos Guild's bones.

It came from a young man who hadn't lived half as long as he had.

Magic Johnson's warning flashed through his mind. *You'd better stop there. Don't do anything rash.*

He understood, too, who that warning had been for.

Step.

By the time he came to his senses, it was already too late. The Guild Master of the Kronos Guild instinctively shifted to the side, and Jin Taekyung walked on as if that were only natural.

Half of the roughly three hundred people surrounding them tried to stop him, then found themselves making way without knowing why. Of those who remained, half merely watched; others closed around Jin as if to escort him.

Amid the frozen air and mounting tension, two men faced each other again at the center of the round table.

Jin Taekyung and Michael Silbert.

Michael Silbert and Jin Taekyung.

Their gazes met and flared—cold yet fiery, fiery yet cold.

A voice rang out clearly enough for everyone to hear.

"Do you know what consequences your actions today, and the truth you've revealed, will bring?"

"Hard to say. I guess all kinds of assholes will come after me now."

Jin Taekyung added calmly, "And the worst of them is standing right in front of me."

A muscle twitched in Michael Silbert's cheek.

His composure had begun to falter the moment Jin Taekyung revealed the truth to everyone.

But it was fine. It was fine.

The throne was still there.

Once the vote began, the place where he sat would become the throne.

Jin Taekyung, on the other hand, had no seat left at this round table.

Soon, he would have no place anywhere in the world.

“I can tell you one thing for certain. Now that the Stone-King’s identity has been revealed, I’m afraid the World Hunter Federation’s first vote will be on your permanent expulsion.”

“Really? Why?”

“If he truly was unlike an ordinary monster, and you’d told us immediately, everyone—including me—would have given it careful thought. But it’s too late. You hid a secret this serious. No one can trust you now.”

“Too bad. Go on.”

“Everything will proceed through legal channels. Those involved will be formally charged and put on trial. And if they resist…”

Michael Silbert continued, his voice raised as if to call out to everyone.

“They’ll be executed on the spot.”

A suffocating silence followed.

But the moment he slowly turned his head toward Jin Taekyung, Michael Silbert could hear a thunderous sound echoing through it.

Thump.

His heart dropped.

Thump. Thump-thump.

His heartbeat quickened. Jin Taekyung’s eyes curved like crescents, their gaze piercing the center of his chest like an awl.

What was it? Why was it?

Why was that bastard smiling even in a situation like this?

Why?

“There’s something I want to ask.”

The world seemed to slow.

His pounding heart and trembling pulse filled his ears. Every one of his senses, fixed on Jin Taekyung, caught the words that followed.

“What if you hadn’t colluded with a monster, but…”

Michael Silbert swallowed as Jin’s words trailed off. Then a quiet remark shook his world.

“You were already no different from one? What would happen then?”

“…!”

No—it shook everyone’s world.

With a contemptuous gaze fixed on something neither human nor monster, Jin delivered one final line.

“Has the wound on your neck healed, Michael?”

Chapter 780

The world was full of events and the possibilities that followed them.

The problem was that none of those possibilities was certain.

No matter how far civilization advanced, no matter how deeply cutting-edge science reached into realms once beyond its grasp, there was no such thing as absolute, one-hundred-percent certainty.

Especially where people, rather than machines, were concerned.

But at this moment—

“Has the wound on your neck healed, Michael?”

Looking at his trembling gray eyes, I was certain.

The unbelievable question that had begun with the tiniest clue had finally revealed its dark shape.

At last, I’d driven Michael Silbert to the edge of a cliff.

But I wiped the smile from my lips. My disgust for the man before me outweighed any pleasure I took in turning the tables.

I despised everything about that man steeped in gray.

“You filthy piece of shit.”

My voice broke the silence.

Unlike when I’d revealed the Skeleton King’s identity, not one person in the room laughed at me this time.

No. They hadn’t fully understood what they’d just heard.

Or perhaps they couldn’t bring themselves to accept a truth so far beyond anything they’d imagined.

“What… what the hell does that mean?”

The Guild Master of Kronos. I kept my eyes on Michael Silbert as I answered.

“Ask him yourself.”

In the suffocating silence, hundreds of pairs of eyes turned toward Michael Silbert. Among those watching were his supporters—some I’d identified through my investigation, and some I hadn’t.

“You were all kissing his ass from every angle earlier. Guess nobody bothered telling you what was really going on. Well, I can see why. Can’t you?”

Michael Silbert didn’t answer. He simply stared at me.

His gray eyes were still unsettled, and I could almost read the thoughts racing through his head.

But—

“Don’t strain yourself trying to figure it out. You already know, don’t you?”

Once all the equations lined up, the answer was clear.

"Michael Silbert."

I felt as if I'd finally found my way out of a maze I'd wandered for ages.

Beyond the walls that had hemmed me in on every side, someone waited at the exit.

A gray monster who'd lingered somewhere between light and darkness, then crossed a river from which there was no return.

The last edge of the veil hiding what he really was.

"You…"

I let out the breath I'd been holding.

"You're fucked now."

Michael Silbert found himself wondering when things had started going wrong. How? Where?

But no matter how hard he thought, he couldn't find an answer.

Everything that had led to this moment came down to one person. Even if Michael found an answer, the man before him would surely create another variable.

Jin Taekyung.

Another name for endless variables.

An Eastern young man far too young, reckless, and frivolous to stand in his way.

Yet Michael Silbert could no longer deny it.

That young man wasn't merely an obstacle to be removed. He was another wall Michael should have broken down at all costs.

Such heat.

The heat in those black eyes.

At the same time, the wound on the back of Michael's neck—still there like a brand—burned with pain.

Tap.

Without realizing it, Michael Silbert reached for his neck.

But when his fingertips met the cold armor that covered it all the way up to his throat, hiding the wound, a dry laugh escaped him.

Excuses? Damage control?

Meaningless now. They would only make him look pathetic.

As a single drop of water could split a rock, one palm-sized bottle of potion was enough to bring down the mountain that was Michael Silbert.

Now that my body can no longer accept the mana in a potion, no excuse will do me any good.

But one question remained.

How had Jin Taekyung learned the secret? And what had made him willing to use a double-edged sword fraught with danger and uncertainty against Michael?

So instead of making excuses, Michael Silbert asked.

“I’ll ask you one thing. How did you find out?”

“…!”

The question was brief, but the shock it sent through the room was immense.

“What… what did you just say?”

“G-Guild Master…”

His words were as good as an admission. The people most shaken were those who had supported Michael Silbert most fervently.

He didn’t so much as glance at his allies, frozen like statues. Just as Jin Taekyung had revealed the truth amid their accusations, Michael repeated himself.

“I asked how you found out.”

The answer was shorter than the question.

“Siegfried Bassmann.”

“Siegfried?”

“Yeah. Turns out the man investigated all sorts of things before he died.”

Whoosh!

A sheet of paper shot through the air like an arrow. Michael Silbert caught it between two fingers and murmured the title written at the top.

“…The Compatibility of Mana and Magical Power.”

“They say he was the greatest monster scholar of his age, even before you count his being a Grand Mage. Looks like he researched just about everything.”

“There shouldn’t have been any research material left.”

“Sure. That’s what people knew.”

Michael Silbert looked down at the paper in his hand. His gray eyes darted across it; he read and understood the entire page in an instant.

“Studying whether a human body could take in a monster’s magical power and coexist with it. Sounds like the sort of insane idea only an eccentric like Siegfried Bassmann would pursue. Of course…”

Jin Taekyung’s low voice reached his ears.

“That wouldn’t have been true for you.”

Michael Silbert raised his head. The paper, now badly crumpled in his grip, caught fire.

Fwoosh. Crumble.

Ash drifted through the air. Beyond it, the eyes that had gone cold now held a reddish glow.

“Looks like Siegfried Bassmann wondered about it too. But even he never managed to prove it. Or maybe he stopped because he thought he’d crossed a taboo.”

Jin Taekyung watched the ash drift toward him and continued.

“Maybe he decided material like this shouldn’t be left behind. Or maybe whoever killed him wanted it gone. Either way, almost nothing remained of that research. It took me a while to find this.”

“You think that’s why I killed him?”

“At first.”

“At first?”

“Yeah. But you killed Siegfried Bassmann for another reason.”

“I won’t deny it. But I’d like to know why you think so.”

“Simple. You’re not careless enough to leave research material like this behind.”

Michael Silbert stared at Jin Taekyung for a moment, then laughed aloud.

“I appreciate that. I’d have been disappointed if even you took me for an idiot.”

“Don’t thank me. I took you for a fucking bastard instead.”

“But you still haven’t given me a clear answer. This material alone couldn’t have been enough to make you suspect me.”

“No, it was enough.”

“Why?”

“When a crime happens, it’s only natural to suspect the ex-convict who lives nearby first.”

“…!”

“I was looking over what little research remained when the thought struck me.”

Jin Taekyung turned his head with a contemptuous sneer.

Now that the truth behind the Grand Mage’s death—long a mystery—had come to light, the stunned crowd stood frozen, watching the two men.

“What if Michael Silbert, that fucking bastard, was already as good as half human and half demon? What if he’d made that absurd research a reality?”

In the utter silence, Jin Taekyung recalled the moment the thought had first come to him.

Before hundreds of watching eyes and listening ears, on a stage someone else had planned meticulously from beginning to end, he spoke as though he stood alone in the spotlight.

“And then… every piece finally fell into place.”

That possibility, one no one else had considered, was the last piece of the complicated puzzle.

It explained how Michael Silbert had recognized the Skeleton King for what he was.

How a man who'd been just one hero among hundreds during the Great Cataclysm had risen from the dragon's tail to its head.

Why the Odin Guild's growth had begun when Cheon Taemin disappeared, and why Michael hadn't shown his face even at Lee Jungryong's funeral, where prominent figures from around the world had gathered.

All of it came down to one thing.

"Magical power."

Jin Taekyung slowly turned around. Looking into the gray eyes that no longer wavered, he continued.

"I don't know how it happened or what gave you the chance, but… you were able to grow stronger by absorbing magical power. Just like a monster."

Yet Michael also held mana within himself. He had perfectly controlled and concealed the balance between the two energies, so no one had discovered what he was.

Not even the Skeleton King.

Whenever they spoke of Michael Silbert, the Skeleton King habitually called him an "unpleasant human." Even he, a monster, couldn't quite say what he meant by it.

If there was one person in the world Michael Silbert feared above all others, one person from whom he had to hide his true nature, it was—

"Cheon Taemin. He would've seen right through you."

As Jin Taekyung's low voice reached everyone in the room, a pair of dry lips parted, breaking the long silence.

"Yes. Because of him, I had to keep my head down for many years. Almost as many as you've been alive."

More than thirty years had passed, but Michael Silbert still remembered it vividly.

He had only recently gained his new power. Amid a great gathering of people, that supreme being's gaze had fixed precisely on him. Fear had gripped his entire body.

Back then, he'd possessed such a tiny amount of magical power that the man hadn't looked his way again. But the fear of that day had never truly faded.

Even after time had passed and Cheon Taemin had vanished. Even after Michael had learned the secrets of Zone A from Siegfried Bassmann.

He hadn't even attended Lee Jungryong's funeral.

The information he had might have been wrong. Cheon Taemin—the only person who could see through him—might have been there.

But…

"There's one thing you've got wrong."

Speaking quietly, Michael Silbert awakened the enormous energy dormant deep within him.

That unprecedented, turbulent power in which light and darkness had mingled for years—but which, from a certain day onward, had been stained a deeper and deeper shade by the swelling darkness.

“The only person in this world I fear isn’t here right now.”

Rumble, rumble, rumble.

A vast wave of force rose and pressed down on everything around them.

Chapter 781

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

A roar shook everything around us.

At the same time, murky energy—light and darkness mixed together—poured out, engulfed the room, and hung over everyone's heads.

Dark.

It was far too early for the sun to have set, yet the National Assembly building had already turned the first page of night.

A night without a bright moon or stars scattered across the sky.

And yet, in a haze fainter than moonlight, someone radiated a presence clearer than anything else.

Step. Step.

The air shifted with each slow step he took.

No, the air wasn't the only thing that had changed.

His gray eyes were slowly turning black, like ink spreading through water.

The characteristically pale skin of a white man was covered in a thin membrane like leather, and his entire body—now longer and thicker—seemed to radiate strength and elasticity unlike anything he'd shown before.

As if…

He wasn't human.

And yet, he wasn't a monster, either.

The immense energy pouring from his body clearly held mana within it.

So what should I call that bastard—Michael Silbert?

His slow footsteps finally stopped.

My face, twisted with contempt, was reflected in his eyes, where darkness rippled.

"You monstrous bastard."

I probably wasn't the only one thinking that.

Shock spread across hundreds of faces.

The best fighters from countries all around the world had gathered here, but no one dared to speak or move.

Every one of them had reached a high realm. They could feel just how vast—and terrifyingly powerful—the aura Michael Silbert was giving off.

And with it, they understood the true meaning of what he'd said earlier.

The only person I fear isn't here right now.

Even I had to admit it, at least to myself.

Michael Silbert hadn't been arrogant after all.

No matter how vile and impure the source of his power was, its sheer scale was beyond anything I'd faced before.

If I had to name one person who came close, it would be the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

But for all their similarities, there was a clear difference between them.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress was constantly supplied with magical power flowing from the rift.

Michael Silbert, on the other hand, had found a way to make magical power coexist with mana—and had made it entirely his own.

Just how much magical power has he absorbed?

I fixed my eyes on Michael Silbert, my gaze sinking deep.

Something that was no longer human, but wasn't a monster, either.

A monster that had spent decades building up its power while evading the notice of an absolute being stood before me.

Now he was revealing every last bit of the strength he'd kept hidden.

With a predator's smile, he looked at me and everyone else before opening his tightly closed lips.

"I told you. As long as he's not here, no one can stop me now."

The air had gone cold. Eyes wavered around the room.

But not everyone here was overwhelmed by Michael Silbert's aura.

"You've gotten a lot better at joking since I last saw you, Michael."

Whoooosh.

A gust of wind suddenly swept through the room.

No—it wasn't wind. It was so much mana that it felt like wind.

Dense smoke rose behind Magic Johnson, who had slung his staff over his shoulder like a steel pipe.

Crackle.

The last stub of his cigar was crushed beneath a military boot. Revived by a fresh dose of nicotine, Chuck Hagel spat out a glob of phlegm.

Flames streamed from his eyes as he glared at Michael Silbert.

"Say that again. Go on, you damned neo-Nazi bastard."

And he wasn't the only one.

Faye Chen had already drawn her bow, and Prince Felix unsheathed an ornate longsword set with brilliant jewels, his bearing full of dignity.

Team Leader Choi, however, did something different.

Shing.

At last, the [Hero's Sword] slid free of its scabbard. He handed it to someone else.

"Please take it. It suits you better than it does me."

The recipient blinked at this unexpected gesture of goodwill, then nodded in thanks.

He silently looked at the sword in his hands before suddenly speaking.

“It’s a little late to say this, but…”

The Skeleton King.

The King of the Dead stared at Michael Silbert and continued.

“From the moment I first saw you, I’ve never liked you.”

Kiiing.

A golden line crossed the Skeleton King’s pure-white forehead, tracing out a crown.

At the same time, a chilling aura at odds with that brilliant light flowed through his body. But this time, no one raised a weapon against him.

Now that the truth was out, it was clear who their enemy was.

Shhhhh.

Weapons and dazzling radiance cut through the murky darkness, all aimed at Michael Silbert.

But the smile on his face remained.

No—it grew broader and more vivid as he spoke.

“Oh, Fabian. You too?”

“…!”

The Guild Master of Kronos, unexpectedly called by name, clenched his jaw.

His eyelids trembled, and the blade in his hand wavered.

Michael Silbert laughed heartily at his obvious agitation, then turned to the others.

“Christopher, Fernando, Joanne, Marcel, Khalid…”

The names of powerful figures spilled from his lips, one after another.

The spark Michael Silbert had struck spread from the Guild Master of Kronos to people throughout the room.

Every one of them was either the head of a major Guild or an S-rank Hunter, yet they froze like statues just from hearing their names.

Race, nationality, gender, age—they differed in every way but one.

Until just a moment ago, they’d all been Michael Silbert’s supporters.

And the ties they’d built over so many years were more tangled and weighty than anyone could imagine.

“Even the shortest of our relationships goes back more than ten years. You all feel like old friends to me. Don’t I to you?”

No one answered. Michael Silbert smiled at those frozen in place.

“If this is what you’ve chosen, I won’t stop you… but think it over once more. Think about the trust and friendship we’ve shared all these years.”

I could feel unease and confusion spreading through the room.

This wasn't simply an appeal to their affection.

Michael Silbert was pressuring the people who'd turned their backs on him.

Behind the words *trust* and *friendship* lurked the ugly secrets only those involved knew. He was using them as leverage.

The spark he'd tossed among them blazed up, feeding on the fear and anxiety hidden deep in their hearts.

Then he said something that made them forget even the little conscience they had left.

"If the whole truth came out, do you think you'd be safe?"

"…!"

"But you needn't worry. History is the spoils of the victor, after all."

Michael Silbert slowly turned his head to look at me and added,

"And not just history. The whole world."

That was the finishing blow.

And just as Fabian, the Guild Master of Kronos, led the Hunters who made up nearly half the people present in lowering their weapons—

A voice slipped from my lips, cold and unfamiliar, as if it belonged to someone else.

"Yeah. I should thank you, actually. For showing yourselves like this, at least."

"What?"

The confusion that crossed Michael Silbert's face didn't last long.

No—almost at once, someone's scream swallowed his voice.

"Argh!"

"Urgh!"

Slash! Splatter!

Fountains of blood shot up amid overlapping screams.

The ambush began on all sides the instant the weapons came down. The Guild Master of Kronos realized what was happening a moment too late and shouted,

"You fucking—!"

"I regret it too, Fabian. I'd hoped it wouldn't come to this."

Magic Johnson had already risen into the air. He answered coolly as he gripped his staff.

Vmmmm.

The air trembled.

Fire and ice filled the sky on a massive surge of mana, then plunged toward the ground like streaks of light.

Toward the traitors who had once been his comrades-in-arms.

Whoosh! Thud-thud-thud!

"St—urgh!"

Three or four A-rank Hunters, relatively weaker than the others, dropped to their knees with dying groans.

Meanwhile, the Guild Master of Kronos, who had been about to hurl his weapon at Magic Johnson in midair, found someone else standing in his way.

"You've gone completely off the rails since I last saw you. Why'd you make such a stupid choice, Fabian, you dumb son of a bitch?"

Grimy military boots. The acrid smell of cigar smoke clinging to his whole body.

The Guild Master of Kronos clenched his jaw as he faced the white man, well past middle age and nearing old age.

"Chuck Hagel."

He was no easy opponent.

No—he was dangerous.

Fabian looked back, hoping for help from his allies, but that hope was in vain.

Just a few steps away, the S-rank Hunters who'd turned to Michael Silbert's side with him were struggling against other enemies.

Faye Chen, Prince Felix, the Skeleton King—who was already raising the dead Hunters and sending them charging—and Choi Minwoo.

There wasn't a hint of hesitation in their swift movements.

"You bastards… You planned this from the start?"

"Once you start, you have to pull it up by the roots."

With a ferocious laugh, Chuck Hagel charged at the Guild Master of Kronos.

Bang!

The air burst with their collision.

But the next moment, more crashes and screams surged in from every direction like waves, drowning it out. Red blood sprayed into the air.

Right. The enemies' blood was red.

Human blood, not monster blood.

The red blood I'd never wanted to see in the world where I was born and raised soaked the National Assembly building and the enormous round table.

Maybe that was why my mouth tasted so bitter and my blood was boiling, even though I'd expected this.

Fwoosh.

The fire dragon coiled in my dantian surged up.

I felt heat like molten lava seep through every part of my body, and suddenly I spoke.

"Fucking awful sight, isn't it?"

Michael Silbert had ignored everything happening around him and watched me in silence. Instead of answering, he asked,

“Is everything happening here your doing?”

“What if it is?”

“Then I applaud your bold decision.”

Bold decision.

The words pierced something in my chest like an awl.

But I kept it off my face and answered calmly.

“Then don’t just flap your gums. Clap your hands, you dumbass.”

“Sorry, but I can’t do that.”

“Why not?”

“Because if I give you even the slightest opening, I have a feeling something will happen. Of course…”

Michael Silbert’s smile faded as he continued.

“That won’t happen.”

“Maybe. You sure about that?”

And just as silence fell for a moment—

Whoosh.

All the space between us vanished, and two immense forces shot toward each other.

Kwaaaang!

Chapter 782

Kwaaaang!

The deafening crash left my ears numb.

But before the ringing came, an enormous shock wave traveled through our hands, which had touched for only an instant.

Boom!

It felt as if a giant's palm had struck my entire body.

The irresistible force sent me flying backward. I twisted in midair, and a blade of gray energy came rushing toward my face.

Shhk!

A hair's breadth. That was all.

I snapped my head aside, and the gray energy skimmed past the tip of my nose, cleaving the ground like soft tofu. I landed lightly on the spot it had cut through.

Then I watched a man walk toward me, his entire body wrapped in gray energy.

No—something that had crossed beyond the bounds of humanity.

"Michael Silbert."

He smiled at the sound of my voice. The shadow in his deep-set dimple seemed especially dark. That wasn't just my imagination.

Crack. Crack.

The ground crumbled beneath each step he took.

The energy pouring from Michael Silbert was so overwhelming that even those fighting nearby choked on their breath and retreated as far as they could.

But not me.

I couldn't back down. I had no intention of doing so.

Just as I'd decided before coming here, I would fight.

To stop that monster strolling toward me. To keep him from hurling billions of people into the flames all over again.

I stepped forward, putting my weight into it.

Whoosh.

One step.

Wind brushed past my body, and space folded. At the same time, two keywords formed in my mind and became commands.

Inventory open. Summon.

The spear I'd hidden where no one could see it settled into my grip.

The world had slowed. Blue-white flames surged along the spearhead, painting the gray eyes where darkness rippled as I brought it down.

Michael Silbert.

Straight for the crown of that monster's head.

Fwoosh!

The concentrated heat evaporated every trace of moisture within several meters.[3146]

Through air hot enough to catch fire at a touch, I saw his eyes widen.

The corners of his mouth were still turned up, even in the face of a strike no one here could have expected.

Then—

A sword flashed upward like a streak of light and struck the spearhead of White Flame as it fell toward his crown.

Kwaang!

A deafening crash rang out, as if the sky itself had split open.

Grrrrk.

The spearhead and sword blade locked together in midair, neither giving an inch. Beyond them came a low laugh.

"So that's it. I'd been wondering why I never saw that spear."

"…!"

"Are you done with the surprise magic trick you prepared?"

Grit.

The sword, wrapped in a murky aura, slowly pushed back the flame-wreathed spearhead.

Strength no human should have possessed and a boundless, unprecedented power burst forth all at once.

Kwaaaah!

The moment I faced that immense force head-on, I knew for certain:

Even my physical abilities, pushed far beyond their limits thanks to the System, and my three jiazi[3147] of internal energy—a level no one in Murim could afford to underestimate—weren't enough to fully suppress his power.

If the fallout reaches the people around us…

I didn't need to think hard about what would happen.

At least dozens would die. Half of them would be heroes who should never die in a place like this.

I had only one option left.

Neutralize it.

With that word flashing through my mind, I let go of White Flame, flung upward by the force of the clash, and thrust out both hands without hesitation.

Flicker. Boom!

[3146] One meter is about 3.28 ft; several meters is roughly several yards.

[3147] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar. Three jiazi equals 180 years.

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist with my right hand. The Flame Divine Palm with my left.

One fist and one palm.

Two branches from the same root—the Fire Gate Clan. From their tips, two streams of flame surged into the murky aura.

Grrrrk!

The tremendous recoil sent throbbing pain through my body. The ground turned over beneath my sliding feet, exposing its ugly innards in long furrows.

But I focused only on the energy in front of me, pouring the flames from both hands into the murky aura.

Not swallowing it—gnawing it away.

Not stopping it—throwing it out of balance.

At last, the mass of destructive energy visibly shrank. I twisted it with all my strength and hurled it behind me.

Whoooosh—Kwaang!

A tearing crash and tremor shook the National Assembly building.

The Skeleton King drove his Bone Sword into the chest of a traitor who had staggered off balance, then shouted, “Watch out!”

It was good advice, but half a beat too late.

Michael Silbert was already right in front of me.

Shwack!

An aura filled with murky light grazed the back of my neck.

I dodged the lightning-fast thrust and slipped inside his reach, driving a fist at him without hesitation.

Boom!

Michael Silbert blocked my Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist with a hand wrapped in layer upon layer of aura, then brought his knee up.

No—just as he was about to, he shoved me away and retreated.

Whoosh! Thwack!

A silver streak plunged from the air, piercing the exact spot where he’d stood a moment ago.

He watched me silently pull White Flame free, then smiled.

“Sure. If it were too easy, it wouldn’t be any fun.”

Fun. That was what he called it.

I looked around at the screams and the blood spraying everywhere. A disbelieving laugh escaped me.

“You crazy bastard. No matter how I look at it, you’re never going to be human again.”

“Even if I’m not human, what of it?”

"What?"

"I've experienced imbalances like this several times before. The stronger my magical power grew, the further it fell out of balance with my mana. There were even times I couldn't control the magical power I absorbed from Magic Gems. But do you know what I thought every time it happened?"

Michael Silbert didn't wait for an answer.

Hundreds of Hunters were fighting a horrific civil war in the same space, but he looked utterly at ease as he watched.

"Demon King."

"…!"

"If someone kept getting in my way. If they prevented me from reaching the pinnacle as a human… I thought becoming the new Demon King after Asmodeus wouldn't be so bad."

I stared at Michael Silbert, at a loss for words. Then I realized I needed to correct what I'd said earlier.

"…Now that I look at you again, you're not just a crazy bastard. You're completely out of your fucking mind."

"Call me whatever you like for now. By the time the sun sets, everything will be decided. Whether you and those friends of yours live or die, and the name the world will know as my true one."

The whole world already knew the name Michael Silbert.

But that wasn't what he meant by his "true name."

Depending on how this fight turned out, he could become the Alliance Leader of the World Hunter Federation—or the new Demon King.

Of course, as far as I was concerned, that was all in Michael Silbert's head.

"Idiot. What's a leech like you going to do?"

"A leech?"

"Yeah, you leeching bastard."

His face slowly stiffened. I let out a scornful laugh.

"An imugi from a clear pond ascends to heaven. Ever seen a grub wriggling in a sewer turn into a dragon? No matter how strong you get, your nature stays the same. At best, you're a mosquito or a leech."

"…!"

"A mosquito drunk on power, with a straw stuck in a Magic Gem. A useless leech that does nothing but suck people's blood. That's what you are, you pathetic bastard."

Pathetic bastard.

Those words were for me, too.

There'd been a time when I'd seriously considered giving up on everything and backing away.

If the end of his pathetic ambition was simply taking control of the World Hunter Federation, if his only goal was to stand at the top… I'd thought maybe no more disasters would happen.

It hurt.

I had the power and abilities everyone wished for, yet I couldn't save the cities collapsing into ruins or the countless people dying inside them.

It felt as though these terrible disasters were happening because I'd stood against Michael Silbert.

That was why, for a little while, I couldn't help but wonder.

No. I was afraid.

Fine. I'd admit it.

I was afraid to keep running down a path strewn with countless dead.

The closer I chased Michael Silbert, the more blood and bodies I feared I'd trample underfoot.

I thought that if I simply handed him the world, he'd stop The Prophet and every other disaster, if only to protect what had become his.

But… now I understood.

When I finally came out of that long, dark tunnel I'd walked alone in my heart, where no one else could see, there was the light I'd wanted so badly.

No. There was an answer.

All of it had come from my own weakness. My foolish hope was wrong, and Michael Silbert was a monster who wouldn't stop running even after he crossed the finish line.

That was why I had to kill him, as a human being.

"No matter how I look at it, the answer is to stomp on leeches like you until they burst. Don't you think?"

"…!"

"From now on, shut your mouth. You're wasting oxygen."

I leveled my spear at Michael Silbert.

His eyes had turned so black there was no trace of their original color. At the same time, an immense, seemingly endless power wrapped around his entire body and began to whirl.

Kwaaaah.

Everything the rising strands of power touched broke and split apart.

His voice, once gentle and unhurried, rang out as though it belonged to something from another world.

"Your corpse will be buried here today, along with every truth that will never come to light."

At his words, I looked up at the cameras installed all around us.

Half had been destroyed, but the rest were still doing their job.

The truth, huh?

I had a fair idea why Michael Silbert, who loved attention so much, wasn't broadcasting the brightest moment of his life to the whole world.

And where was that damned pet crow that always followed him like a shadow? Why was everything outside still so quiet despite all this chaos?

But right now, there was only one thing I could say to him.

"I said shut your mouth, you fucking bastard."

"You…!"

Grrrrrrk!

As I charged toward his energy, surging like waves across a boundless sea, I suddenly wondered why that immense power—enough to make even my three jiazi[3148] of internal energy feel hopelessly inadequate—didn't frighten me.

Why Michael Silbert, who'd absorbed a Magic Gem and gained physical abilities comparable to mine and a seemingly inexhaustible supply of magical power, seemed so small.

And as I thrust out the spearhead, I found the answer.

Because I'm a Hunter.

Hunters aren't afraid of their prey.

Whoooosh!

[3148] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar. Three jiazi equals 180 years.

Chapter 783

Whoooosh!

As I charged, the spearhead flashed forward, cleaving through space. Flames surged up, burning the air and erasing the wind as they pierced the thick darkness.

Boom!

One precise point pierced the invisible flow.

Some of the magical power sweeping toward me like a wave dispersed helplessly. My vision plunged through the gap in the magical power at the same speed as my thrust—and a familiar face came into view.

No. Familiar and strange at once.

Because the Michael Silbert standing there was no longer Michael Silbert.

“Not bad.”

The moment that chilling voice reached my ears—

Shhk.

His figure vanished as if it had been erased.

My target disappeared from sight, but instead of panicking, I twisted around on instinct.

Whoosh!

A sword sprang up behind me, skimmed my side, and stabbed through empty air.

If I hadn’t dodged, it would have pierced my heart. I spun and struck with my palm.

Kwaang!

His body was supposed to be flesh and bone. Yet when our palms met, the impact sounded like an explosion.

And the shock wave hit even harder.

Grrrrk!

The ground tore up beneath my sliding feet. I was driven back several meters[3149] while Michael Silbert stood rooted to the spot. One corner of his mouth curled upward.

“Do you understand now how foolish it was to stand against me?”

Ptoo.

I spat out the blood pooled in my mouth instead of answering. Before it hit the ground, I stepped forward with all my strength.

Kwaang!

The ground shattered beneath my foot.

[3149] Several meters is roughly several yards; 1 m is about 3.28 ft.

Wind swept over me as I crossed more than ten meters[3150] in an instant. My spear and his sword flashed toward each other.

Kaaang!

The sharp clash burst the air around us. His sword had grown so long and massive it hardly looked like a sword anymore, swollen with magical power. It knocked my spearhead far aside.

Crack.

Pain shot through my wrist.

This wasn't just a difference in physical ability. It was a difference in the sheer amount of power we held.

Absorbing the Magic Gem had made Michael Silbert's body much stronger, and the magical power welling up without end reinforced it further. Of course he was pushing me back.

As long as I insisted on fighting him head-on.

Grrrrk!

I turned my spearhead in a smooth arc, and his blade slid along it.

Despite the enormous difference in force, Michael Silbert's sword slipped out of his control. My hunch confirmed, I drove a fist toward him.

Fwoosh, whoom!

Flames burst forth in a flash.

The thick darkness moved like a living creature and hurried to envelop its master, but my Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, thrown with all my strength, burned through the magical power and slammed into his chest.

Kwaaaang!

A deafening crash rang out, and his body flew away like a cannonball.

Michael Silbert hastily flung out both arms, pouring magical power toward me to keep me back. Then he coughed up blood.

Kh-erk.

I cut down every bolt of magical power flying toward me and watched him stagger. A strange feeling stirred in me.

Not because I'd finally landed a solid hit. Because the blood spilling from his mouth was red.

"So even a monster like you is still human. For now, anyway."

Michael Silbert clenched his teeth at my mutter. His eyes trembled; he hadn't expected that blow.

"What did you do?"

I answered readily.

[3150] 10 m is about 33 ft, so the distance here is slightly greater.

“Four Ounces Deflecting a Thousand Catties.”

“What?”

“You don’t need to understand. There’s a shitload of things in this world you don’t know about anyway.”

“…!”

“So I don’t bother trying to understand, either. You, or those lunatics fighting over there—who knows what kind of fucked-up shit they got up to while working with you to end up in that fight? None of it makes any sense to me.”

I stared straight at Michael Silbert.

“No. The moment I understood it, I’d become the same kind of idiot.”

A new emotion spread across his face, over the traces of pain.

Anger. Or humiliation.

Watching his face twist felt better than I’d expected.

“I told you earlier. A leech is still a leech. It couldn’t become a dragon even if it died and came back to life.”

“You bastard…”

“Yeah. Putting everything else aside, I’ll give you one thing.”

My breath was as hot as a fire dragon’s. I stepped toward him.

“You’re the strongest leech I’ve ever met.”

With that, I hurled White Flame without hesitation, gripping it in reverse.

Bang!

The air burst in layer after layer, as if a sonic boom had gone off.

And at the end of its path stood Michael Silbert.

Kwaang! Grrrrrung!

Flame and magical power erupted together.

The stained glass, which had barely held its shape thanks to dozens of layers of defensive magic, couldn’t withstand the shock wave and shattered. I flashed through the rain of countless shards falling overhead and thrust out both palms.

Boom!

A gale of flame swept through the room.

Amid the haze left by the explosion, the shadow of someone staggering was etched clearly into my eyes.

That’s him.

No doubt about it.

I kicked off the ground and charged, reaching out to grab empty air.

No—two spears appeared as if drawn into existence by the command I shouted in my mind. I caught them and launched them once more.

Shweeeek!

Two streaks of light crossed the space between us.

When Michael Silbert twisted aside and dodged the spears, I tore through the darkness surrounding us again and closed in right in front of him.

“Jin Taekyung!”

Whooom!

Beyond his furious shout came the heavy whistle of a weapon cutting through the air.

Fed an absurd amount of magical power, the enormous blade came down as if to cleave me in two.

Shwaaaak! Shhk!

Space split open, and the sword, having missed its target, cleaved the ground.

Pain stung across my chest. I’d dodged sideways at the last moment, but the pressure behind the sword was stronger—and sharper—than I’d imagined.

His strength and speed made my hair stand on end.

But just as he had a vast store of power I could never possess, I had something he lacked.

Something more important than the amount of internal energy you held when your life was on the line.

Martial arts.

Thump! Grrrrk!

As he raised his sword again, I drew up my internal energy and stamped down.

Using the Thousand-Catty Drop, I pressed the blade beneath a crushing weight.

Michael Silbert’s eyes widened.

“…!”

A natural reaction from someone encountering martial arts for the first time. I’d been astonished every day when I first learned proper martial arts from Jeok Cheongang.

But Michael Silbert was neither my teacher nor my disciple. He was a monster I had to kill.

An enemy, plain and simple. I owed him no friendly explanation.

Fwoosh.

The Flame Divine Palm, now at the eighth stage, poured out a dreadful heat.

It was too late for him to free the hand gripping his sword. As he thrust out his other hand, I gave a command in my mind.

Inventory open. Summon.

Thwack!

Instead of a crash, blood burst out. Michael Silbert clenched his teeth at the sight of the dagger that had pierced his magical power and his palm.

His eyes bulged, pain mingling with some realization I couldn’t read.

"This is…!"

Meticulous as he was, Michael Silbert might already have suspected I had an Inventory.

But I was stronger than he thought—and even better at improvising.

Even if he'd guessed, it wouldn't have changed much.

The amount of internal energy you have is only one factor in deciding who lives and who dies.

The powerful opponents who'd fallen at my hands could serve as witnesses, prosecutors, and judges all at once.

Some called me the greatest young prodigy and the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. Others called me a lucky man who'd suddenly gained tremendous power through reawakening.

They were all wrong.

I'd been an F-rank Hunter, born in muddy water. I'd struggled and grown through countless brushes with death.

I would keep struggling with all my might until every bit of dirt filling this pit around me was gone. Until it finally became a clear pond.

And yet… I couldn't hand my pond over to some leech. Not a mantis, not a toad—a leech.

Especially one that would fill it with blood instead of muddy water.

Thrust, thrust-thrust!

My hand flashed.

Still clutching Michael Silbert's hand, pierced by the dagger, I summoned another weapon from my Inventory and slashed, stabbed, twisted, and drove it into him wherever I could.

"Graaah!"

Blood sprayed from his wide-open mouth. At the same time, the hand that had belatedly let go of the sword hilt drove into my side like a battering ram.

Whoom!

The air whistled with a weight that made my skin crawl.

He had the magical power of two or three S-rank monsters combined and enough raw strength to tear a large monster apart with his bare hands.

The System had given me a body like steel, but I wouldn't come away unscathed if that blow landed.

At least, if I did nothing.

Inventory open. Summon.

Crack!

The impact jolted my upper body. I heard bones shift, and a little blood welled into my mouth.

But that was all.

Michael Silbert's desperate punch had neither split my skin nor broken my bones.

It had only damaged part of the red-tinged armor that had appeared around my upper body.

Beep.

> **System** Part of the **Fire Dragon Armor** has been destroyed!
>
> **Current damage:** 44%
>
> At 90% damage or higher, it will be recalled to the Inventory and enter automatic repair mode.

As the alert sounded in my ears, I smiled brightly at Michael Silbert, who had frozen in a daze.

"Mm-hmm. I can just repair it~"

"…!"

And in that instant—

Ptoo!

I spat the blood pooled in my mouth into his face.

As he flailed instinctively, his face drenched in blood, I drove my fist into him.

Like hammering a nail farther into the ground.

Kwaang! Grrrrk!

A heavy crash and tremor swept in all directions. The ground around us sank into a vast crater. At its bottom, Michael Silbert lay sprawled, coughing up blood after my Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist struck him squarely in the chest.

"Khk, k-kergh…!"

The blood he coughed up pooled in the crater.

His armor had long since been smashed to pieces. Blood and soot had stained his once-pale skin dark red.

"…You fucking idiot."

I smiled bitterly. When I reached out, White Flame's shaft shot into my grasp.

Without hesitation, I raised the spearhead.

Whoosh!

Chapter 784

Shwoosh!

It was strange.

I'd only raised my spear. So where had that whistle cutting through the air beside my ear come from?

And what the hell gave those idiots the confidence to charge at me?

In that brief instant, split into even smaller fragments, I turned and brought my spearhead down.

Whooom. Kaang!

The pressure bursting along the spearhead knocked away a dozen or so daggers. At the same moment, two swords came slashing in from either side, aiming for my upper and lower body at once.

Shhk, slice!

It burned like I'd been scalded.

An alert sounded to tell me the durability of my Fire Dragon Armor had dropped, and a considerable stream of blood gushed from my thigh.

Still, that was a decent price for fending off a surprise attack by three S-rank Hunters.

Even more so if I'd given as good as I got, instead of being the only one to take a hit.

Pshaaa!

Blood sprayed belatedly, soaking the ground. A middle-aged man and woman stared wide-eyed as they saw their comrade collapse, his chest split wide open.

"When did you—!"

"No, Fernando!"

It had all happened so quickly that I hadn't had time to see who they were. But now that I was facing them, I recognized them all too well.

S-rank Hunters who represented their respective countries and stood as symbols of humanity.

Or rather, who *had*.

"Well, look who it is. I know all of you."

At my greeting, tinged with a hollow laugh, the middle-aged pair swallowed hard.

Fernando Lucas, Brazil's S-rank Hunter, had made the reckless choice to aim for my chest. Even as he spilled an enormous amount of blood, he was fumbling for a potion with trembling hands.

He looked so desperate that I spoke to him in the warm voice of a romantic lead.

"Drink that, and I'll kill you."

"…!"

"But hold on until this is over and I'll get you treated. I'll even find you a nice prison. All right? Promise."

Fernando Lucas stared at me as though he'd forgotten the pain.

Then he shoved the potion into his mouth with lightning speed.

Bottle and all, without even removing the cap.

Crunch! Thud!

Shattered glass and potion poured into his open mouth.

But even a Top-Grade Potion, capable of restoring torn organs in the blink of an eye, couldn't bring back someone who was already dead.

"I told you not to drink it."

I murmured to Fernando Lucas's corpse, a hole through his forehead where my Finger Qi had struck.

The two middle-aged Hunters who'd survived him—slightly luckier and far more skilled—spoke with rigid faces.

"Did it really have to come to this?"

"It's not too late, Jin. If you stop, we'll withdraw. There's no need for any more sacrifices, is there?"

Stop? No need for more sacrifices?

For a moment, I had no words. I looked around the National Assembly, where the floor was still being stained with blood, then at Michael Silbert, sprawled there and twitching like an insect.

Finally, I looked at the two people standing in front of him and thrust out my spear.

One of the few lessons I'd learned was that I didn't have to answer every stupid thing people said.

Shhk!

They might not know martial arts, but they were S-rank Hunters with plenty of combat behind them.

They gasped and barely dodged the attack, landing in front of and behind me. The spearhead had come without warning, and their eyes had turned grave.

"So that's your answer?"

"Wait. Don't provoke him for no reason. Right now, we need to save Michael first __"

The woman had a much better grasp of the situation than the man, but she made me want to laugh just as much.

What the hell had they been doing all this time? How much had they done for things to come to this?

There'd been a time when I hadn't known anything, either.

Back when I'd gone mechanically from Gates to my goshiwon[3151] and back. I'd fought monsters for money, not out of some sense of duty as a Hunter, yet I'd still felt vaguely offended whenever I heard someone say Hunters had become corrupt.

But… now I knew too much.

There was no going back.

I didn't care what they'd accomplished or how valuable they might be in the war to come.

If we didn't cut out the tumors rooted deep in society, humanity would collapse before it could fight the monsters.

Another Lee Jungryong. Another Go Jun. Another Michael Silbert. They were right in front of me.

The moment they'd turned their weapons against us despite the ugly truth being exposed, they'd become tumors that had to be cut out.

"I already gave you a chance. The choice… was yours."

I charged without hesitation at the people I'd once admired and respected.

Shweeeek!

It was ironic. Pain tormented people, yet as death drew near, they could no longer feel it.

And… that numbness was more frightening than any terrible pain.

Ah.

Michael Silbert blinked blankly.

His lips were slightly parted, but he couldn't even groan. The strength was draining from his arms and legs, from which powerful energy had surged without pause. The blood that had soaked his body and was now sloshing around him felt dull and distant.

Damn it.

If this was how he fell, what had he lived for?

Grrk. Cough.

Instead of a hollow laugh, a bloody bubble welled in his mouth. His head tipped to the side as if he were collapsing, and he saw the corpse of a man frozen with his eyes wide open.

A familiar face.

Fernando Lucas.

[3151] A *goshiwon* is a Korean boarding house offering small, inexpensive rooms, often with shared facilities.

Fernando had been a gang member since childhood, a delinquent who'd won fervent support among South America's poor. Over the past ten years, Michael Silbert had done him various "favors."

The public and the courts would, of course, call those favors something else.

It started small.

But time dulled everything, and each repetition made it snowball.

He'd eliminated a powerful rival and disguised the killing as an accident. He'd used a politician with the right connections to bury tax-evasion charges. He'd even kidnapped a brave journalist and his family when the man was preparing an article about how the hero of Brazil's poor secretly ran a gang and made a fortune on the side.

The others spilling blood and dying for him throughout the chamber were no different.

No. They aren't doing this for me.

Michael Silbert knew why they fought.

They fought for themselves. They knew there was too much to lose if they admitted and accepted everything now.

In the end, he and they were nothing but filth seething in the same pit.

But thanks to that—thanks to how long he'd indulged their greed and ambition—Michael Silbert had bought himself a little time.

Precious time to cast off the human bonds he'd clung to until the end and become the Demon King.

Slosh. Splash.

The blood that had filled the crater rippled like a wave. Through his blurred vision, he saw a spearhead flash through the air and graze the neck of a middle-aged man.

Slice!

A body fell with a wet thud. A head rolled toward him, its eyes meeting his.

The scent of blood rising from the blackened cut, as though it had been seared, smelled as sweet as chocolate. He doubted he was imagining it.

Heh-heh.

Michael Silbert laughed softly. Now that he could make a sound again, his five senses gradually sharpened.

His quickening heartbeat thundered in his ears.

Thump. Thump-thump. Thump-thump-thump!

As his heart beat faster, the blood pooled in the crater surged toward its owner.

But it was no longer red.

Thick, gleaming green blood that no one could mistake for a human's.

The same blood spilled by the unprecedented monster he'd encountered in Paris more than thirty years ago, when the city had overflowed with blood and corpses, filled Michael Silbert's entire body.

Its endless magical power and Regeneration came with it.

Shhhh!

The blood was sucked deep into his body. Severed muscles rejoined. Broken bones and ruined organs mended.

A short scream rang out, as though to celebrate his return from the brink of death.

"Kh-erk!"

It was a victory cry announcing the resurrection of one life—and a death rattle announcing the end of another.

A middle-aged woman staggered backward with a hole through her chest.

A hero of the Great Cataclysm with an impressive record—and filth from the pit Michael Silbert had chosen—even at the brink of death, she drove a dagger into a gap in Jin Taekyung's damaged armor. Her back arched like a bow.

Crunch. Pshaaa!

The spearhead came free, and blood spurted.

Thump.

In front of the corpse that had crumpled like a rotten log stood a young man, tall as an iron tower. Michael Silbert saw him.

—Jin Taekyung.

Michael Silbert looked at Jin Taekyung. No—Jin Taekyung looked at Michael Silbert.

At his eyes, swallowed by utter darkness, with none of their former gray or even their whites remaining.

And… at the monster spreading enormous wings made of magical power.

Whooosh!

The National Assembly, with a radius of hundreds of meters,[3152] fell silent. So did the fierce battle within it, just as it had been nearing its end.

Everyone was stunned into silence at the sight of Michael Silbert, who had lost all semblance of human form.

Scales covered his body. Two horns jutted from his forehead. At the sight of his vast, dark wings, the name of a monster flashed through their minds.

Someone voiced it in a near-groan.

"…Dragon."

The origin and very embodiment of the dragonkin, born with nightmarish power.

[3152] Hundreds of meters is roughly hundreds to a few thousand feet; 200–900 m is about 660–3,000 ft.

The oldest and worst of monsters, with magical power that never ran dry, strength enough to tear heaven and earth apart, and tremendous Regeneration.

Then people remembered a fact they'd forgotten.

In the Great Battle of Paris more than thirty years ago—the battle that had made Michael Silbert who he was—the creature that had claimed a thousand lives, including four S-rank Hunters, had been a young Dragon. It hadn't even reached full maturity.

And its Dragon Heart had never been found.

—Yes. Now do you understand?

Michael Silbert laughed aloud.

The roar shook the entire National Assembly, and several people seized by Fear turned deathly pale.

But one man did not.

Whoooom.

A dreadful mass of energy gathered around the two horns rising from Michael Silbert's forehead. Jin Taekyung watched the Breath form without a trace of panic.

He merely looked on for a moment before tossing out a single word like a sigh.

"Fucking bastard. I'm already in bad shape…"

And the next moment—

Whooosh!

Immense darkness poured down, staining the whole world, and collided with blue-white flames swirling along the spearhead.

Gooooong.

At the end of it all came a blinding flash.

Chapter 785

It was a reverberation.

More than a roar—a sound that left their ears muffled.

Gooooong.

Darkness and flames collided, then mingled.

Everyone watched as the two immense forces drew in wind, air, and debris, slowly swelling. A red warning light flashed through their minds, along with a single word.

Annihilation.

Before power unlike anything they had ever felt, everything else seemed meaningless.

If it burst, everything within a few hundred meters[3153] would turn to ash.

No—the blast might reach beyond the National Assembly and sweep across the entire city.

At this rate… even the civilians will get hurt.

But not everyone was thinking of the civilians.

They might all have sensed the same danger, but they stood on opposite sides of it. Some fought to protect the world of the people outside. Others had turned their weapons on them to protect only their own.

That difference soon showed in what each side did.

“Get them!”

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

With their backs to the cliff’s edge, the traitors had nowhere left to retreat.

Already outnumbered, those who had chosen Michael Silbert seized on the sudden upheaval and made one last desperate attack.

Their numbers had been cut in half, but their auras flashed with more vicious intent than ever.

Krrrraack!

A massive Tower Shield split apart. The ground opened like a block of tofu under a knife.

Lethal strikes rushed in from every direction. A moment’s carelessness would cost someone their life, yet no one stepped back.

They were Hunters.

Even if the word meant nothing more to those traitors than a faded slogan, they had upheld what it meant to be a Hunter—and they would continue to do so.

That was their duty. The responsibility that came with their strength.

[3153] A few hundred meters is roughly 660–1,640 ft, or 0.12–0.31 mi.

“Mr. Johnson!”

Choi Minwoo shouted as if giving a battle cry and swung his sword with all his might.

Its wielder was drenched in blood, but a dazzling crescent of aura swept through the air, grazed past the towering Black man standing there, and cleaved the dozens of arrows flying toward him.

Shhk!

The severed arrows scattered before Johnson’s eyes.

Even amid the battle raging on every side, Magic Johnson drew a deep breath and gathered his mana, muttering to himself.

I keep telling him to call me Johnson.

When this battle was over—when the blood finally stopped flowing—he would tell Choi Minwoo again that there was no need to be so formal with him.

He wanted to clap Faye Chen on the shoulder as she drew her bowstring with bloodied fingers. Prince Felix, too, fighting drenched in blood despite his noble station. And Chuck Hagel, who had just ripped off the Kronos Guild Master’s arm.

No. He wanted to get drunk, laugh, and talk with every Hunter who survived.

And Jin would surely be there.

Yeah, Jin. You’ll be there.

His unheard words dissolved into the reverberation.

Through the blinding light now filling the National Assembly, Johnson caught a hazy glimpse of a young man.

He saw someone else running toward him without hesitation—toward the heart of the disaster.

Chrrrrrrk!

Something white as snow surged forward like a wave.

It sealed every gap around Jin Taekyung and Michael Silbert, the two figures who stood opposed with neither able to give way.

As it took shape, Magic Johnson smiled faintly and roused every bit of mana in his body. He spread it throughout the National Assembly as if to wrap the whole world in it, then spoke.

“Absolute Shield.”

The spell consumed the Grand Mage’s vast reserves of mana and spread across a radius of several hundred meters[3154].

Whooosh.

Then the light finally burst forth, filling everyone’s vision.

[3154] A few hundred meters is roughly 660–1,640 ft, or 0.12–0.31 mi.

In a sliver of time divided into moments finer still—

Boom! Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The world shook with a roar so vast it hurt. Pitch-black darkness and flashes of light flickered before my eyes. Sensations flooded through my body.

Pain. Heat. Cold. Wetness.

And… weight.

It pressed down on my whole body, almost more than I could bear.

Huff. Huff.

My breathing was ragged. I struggled to clear my blurred vision, then drove the shaft of my spear into the ground to support myself.

Thump.

At times like this, I was glad I'd chosen a spear.

It reminded me of what the red-capped Instructor had said when I first arrived at the Hunter Training Center and he handed out our weapons.

"Just use a spear. Spears are the best."

"Yes, sir. Sorry, but may I ask why?"

"What's your Awakening Grade?"

"F-rank, sir."

"Right. There's your answer. In a fight between weaklings like you, reach is everything. I've used one, so I know. And another important thing…"

"What's that, sir?"

"It looks cool."

"Sorry, I didn't quite catch that…?"

"I said it looks cool. Look. Say you meet an enemy. You fight like hell, one-on-one. You both use every last bit of strength until neither of you can lift a finger. Who falls over first—the guy with the sword or the guy with the spear?"

"The guy with weaker legs, I'd think."

"Wrong. The guy with the sword. Every time."

"Could you tell me why, sir…?"

I still remembered the Instructor's answer, delivered with a solemn expression.

"The guy with the spear can use it as a cane."

"Sir?"

"Jam it into the ground or a wall and you've got something to lean on. The guy with the sword has to fall. Why? His sword's too short. That's what decides it: one man down, one man standing. What do you think? Like a scene from a movie, right?"

"Ah."

"Good. Decided what weapon you want?"

"Yes, sir."

"What is it?"

"A bow."

"Get down."

It was a stupid, dusty old memory.

He'd promptly whacked me on the ass about twenty times with a spear shaft from the armory, then practically forced me to take that spear as my first weapon.

The next day, he turned up for our first training session with a sword at his side. I learned one of life's great truths.

This line of work was crawling with some truly spectacular assholes.

But even that Instructor, who must have stayed at the training center for the pleasure of messing with recruits like me, couldn't have imagined where his stupid joke would lead.

That because of his stupid little joke, I'd be standing here now.

That the F-rank Hunter he'd seen back then would make Michael Silbert kneel just a little over ten years later.

Thump.

I raised my head at the heavy sound that pierced my ears.

Through my blurred vision, I saw him trembling on one knee.

Michael Silbert's wings of magical power were gone. So were his gleaming black scales. He stared at me, panting.

"Y-you bastard…"

Cough.

With a cough, a torrent of bloody fluid mixed with bits of his organs poured out.

He'd exhausted all his magical power, and his body refused to heal as it had before, no matter how badly he wanted it to.

No. It would never heal like that again.

Michael Silbert was going to…

Die today. By my hand.

I had no strength to say it aloud. I spoke the words in my head, gritted my teeth, and used White Flame to push myself upright.

Then I walked toward him.

Thud.

Pain tore through my body with every step, as though I might break apart.

Or perhaps I already had.

Beep. Beep. Beep-beep!

Strange.

My eardrums had burst, and my ears had been ringing for a while, but the System's warning beeps were still loud and annoying.

My body must be pretty thoroughly wrecked.

A hollow laugh escaped me. It didn't matter.

Since when had I ever worried about my condition in a fight?

I was happier that I'd finally brought Michael Silbert down—and that, despite the immense aftermath, all those familiar faces had made it through alive.

Of course, not everyone felt the same joy I did.

"Jin Taekyung!"

The middle-aged giant charging at me—the Kronos Guild Master—certainly didn't.

As proof of how fierce the fighting had been, he'd lost an arm to some powerful fighter I couldn't identify. Unable to accept that his life was over, he charged at me.

Then a fierce rush of air sounded behind me, and he had no choice but to accept it.

Boom!

An absurdly huge War Hammer swept past. The Kronos Guild Master's face vanished.

Behind his corpse, which crumpled like a rotten log, Chuck Hagel stood posed like a shot-putter.

He stared at me for a moment, let out a short laugh, and turned to charge the remaining traitors.

He had a warm little line to thaw their frozen hearts.

"Let's keep playing to the end, you sons of bitches."

Cheers and screams mingled in my muffled ears. Some fell, spraying blood. Others stepped over their bodies and pressed on.

The tide had turned.

Even if the goddess of fate showed up to tip the scales back, all we had to do was take her down, too.

Just as I would take down the monster struggling to rise now that I was right in front of him.

Thud.

When had I gotten this close?

I stopped. Like an old man who had leaned on his cane through a long journey to see a lifelong friend, I greeted him, weary but glad to have arrived.

"Hey. I'm here."

Clang!

His answer was the still-brilliant blue blade of his sword.

But even an edge forged from Dragon Bone, a material beyond compare, couldn't cut through Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. There was nowhere near enough strength or speed behind the strike.

Even I, barely able to stand, could block it with ease.

And return his rude greeting.

Thud. Crunch.

Michael Silbert's eyes flew wide. Both arms crumpled. Blood and a scream he couldn't force out bubbled in his open mouth.

Grrk. Grrrk.

Blood spurted intermittently, splattering my face.

But why?

If I thought about what he'd done up until now, the scent of blood seeping into my nose should have been sweet. But all I could smell was something revolting.

Maybe that was why I stopped.

Why the face reflected in his eyes, dark with blood and tears, looked twisted into a monster's.

"…So this is the world you wanted so badly?"

I knew he couldn't give me the answer I wanted, no matter what I asked.

No answer could calm this heart and these emotions threatening to burst out of me.

But I still wanted to hear him speak. I had to.

For all the people who had died because of his pathetic ambition.

"Answer me."

Grab.

I seized Michael Silbert's one remaining horn and hauled him upright. Fighting the pain that surged through me, I whispered to him as he slipped closer to death.

"Say something. Anything. Come on."

And then I understood.

I knew where his other horn had gone. Why I hadn't seen it anywhere nearby.

Thud.

The horn shot up from somewhere and pierced a palm with a dull, wet sound.

But there was no blood. No groan from someone enduring the pain.

Only Michael Silbert's trembling gaze, fixed over my shoulder, and his voice.

"How dare… How dare a monster like you…"

"Wrong. I'll tell you once, and only once, so remember it."

I knew that voice. I realized who stood behind me and laughed aloud.

"My name is Stone-King, you hideous monster."

Chapter 786

“My name is Stone King, you hideous monster.”

The moment he spat out those words as if biting them off, the Skeleton King finally understood.

He had found the answer to the question that had tormented him for so long.

All those nights when everyone else slept and he could not. All those days when everyone else went about their lives and he alone remained dead.

And the question that had bound his body and mind like a chain.

Who am I?

No matter how hard he’d thought about it, he’d never found an answer. But the answer had been there all along, within the Skeleton King himself.

So that’s it.

The Skeleton King muttered to himself.

In the black eyes he saw over a man’s shoulder, the radiance cast by his golden crown was reflected.

“What, exactly, did you want to become?”

Michael Silbert’s eyes trembled at the offhand question.

The Skeleton King continued calmly.

“There was a time when I desperately wanted to know. I tried to recover a past I can no longer remember, and I didn’t know what to call the person I am now.”

That was why he had followed a human he’d met one day out of a forest filled with nothing but death and darkness, and into an unfamiliar world.

“I wanted to find the answer in the world you live in. I believed I could.”

But he hadn’t. Even there, amid enormous metal things rolling on wheels and buildings taller than trees, the answer was nowhere to be found.

To the Skeleton King, who had left the forest in search of it, the human world was simply another forest.

“I can’t breathe or sleep. I can’t feel the cool breeze other humans talk about, or the taste of food. I can’t even feel the faintest pain.”

That was when he first learned that being unable to feel pain could itself be painful. And that some kinds of pain lay in the truth itself.

Monster.

It was the first word the Skeleton King had searched online the day he received a smartphone. One of the words he’d heard most often in the human world. A word for beings like him.

His questions gave way to an emotion he’d never felt before.

Anguish.

Anguish at having awakened as a monster through no choice of his own.

Fear that, to the people he had begun to talk with, share his feelings with, and grow close to, he might be nothing more than a monster.

"I wanted to deny that I was one of them. So I fought alongside you, and for you, with everything I had. I believed it was the right thing to do."

He still believed it. Otherwise, he would never have considered sacrificing himself here today.

The Skeleton King didn't want the humans he cared about to fall before the world did.

Humans were more complicated than he'd imagined. Some harbored terrible rage and killing intent, as monsters did—or worse.

But humans also knew restraint and love. They thought and acted according to their own will.

When petty disputes left countless people dead or injured, when children still little more than infants were abandoned in the street, it was humans who took those children into their arms.

That was why the Skeleton King had wanted to become human like them. To be welcomed among them not as a monster, but as a neighbor and a friend.

And why realizing it was impossible had driven him to despair.

But…

"Not anymore."

The Skeleton King murmured calmly and gripped the horn piercing the back of his hand.

Crack.

He caught Michael Silbert's hand around the horn as well. Though it had been bent and broken earlier, it was slowly healing.

A voice seething with fury escaped through Michael's clenched teeth.

"You think… you think doing this will make a mere monster like you human…?"

"It doesn't matter."

"What?"

"I know. I'm a monster, so I can't be called human. And because I live among humans, I can't be called a monster."

The Skeleton King smiled faintly.

"What does that matter? This is enough."

"…!"

"You hideous, pitiful monster. Let me introduce myself once more."

Looking into Michael Silbert's wide eyes, the Skeleton King spoke slowly.

"I am the master of the Black Forest, the ruler of all the undead, and a hero of this world who fought for you humans. Call me the Skeleton King or the Stone King. Whatever name you give me is part of who I am. But…"

Tap.

The Skeleton King raised a hand and rested it on a man's shoulder.

"I won't tell you the first name I was given in this world."

Because that was a name only a friend could use.

"Isn't that right, Jin Taekyung? You conniving human."

I didn't know what to say.

Should I laugh at the bastard for finally coming to his senses? Get angry? Or smack him upside the head as hard as I could, like I usually did?

Like someone who'd forgotten how to speak, I sank into a brief but deep debate before suddenly opening my mouth.

"Golgoli, you stupid son of a bitch."

Bones.

The first name I'd given the undead I'd met in the Black Forest.

Usually he'd have thrown a fit and told me not to call him that. Today, his answer was meek.

"I admit it. I was a stupid son of a bitch."

"…"

"I won't doubt you again."

Damn it.

I was speechless. I had nothing to say. But somehow, I didn't feel frustrated at all.

I just… felt relieved.

As if a stone had lifted from my chest. As if the last bit of distance between us had finally vanished.

Yeah. That was enough.

Feeling lighter, I threw a punch.

Thwack!

Michael Silbert's face snapped back. I still had him by the hair, and he'd been standing there looking half out of it.

I didn't even let him fall.

Thwack, thwack. Crack.

His proud nose caved in. Teeth spilled through his mangled lips.

I hit him until blood or tears ran down his cheeks from eyes veined with burst capillaries. Until his twitching limbs went limp.

Crack. Crunch.

I kept hitting him. Breaking him. Crushing him.

Every time I moved, every time my fists and feet slammed into him, the lingering aftermath of One Annihilation sent excruciating pain through my whole body. But I didn't care.

If someone hadn't grabbed my wrist, I might have beaten Michael Silbert to death right there.

Grab.

"Please stop, Mr. Jin. Not yet."

A familiar voice, worn with exhaustion.

I turned without thinking and blinked. Team Leader Choi stood there, drenched from head to toe in blood.

No. Everyone was there.

"Jin, it's over. It's finally… finally over."

Magic Johnson approached with Chuck Hagel supporting him. He smiled weakly, but there was no joy in it, despite their victory in a battle that had decided their fate.

After killing people who had once been his comrades, the hero's smile was dark and bitter.

Just like the silence that had settled over us, and everyone surrounding me.

"Oh."

A sound escaped me—part gasp, part groan.

Only then did I raise my head and look around. Everything they'd said was true.

Whoooosh.

A wind heavy with the smell of blood swept past.

Abandoned weapons and corpses filled every part of my view.

Pools of blood on the floor soaked our shoes. The enormous Round Table, once a symbol of the heroes who had saved the world, had been shattered, leaving only ruins behind.

Yeah. It was over.

The first battle for humanity's fate.

The battle between duty and self-interest. Between humans and monsters.

It had ended here—and outside, where blood had been spilled beyond our sight.

Creeeeak. Boom.

The entrance door, already half broken, toppled with a heavy crash. Weary footsteps followed as people climbed over it.

Clank. Clank.

Their armor and weapons were soaked in blood.

At the sight of the blood-drenched figures filing in, quite a few of the surviving Hunters reached for their weapons. They stopped when Team Leader Choi spoke.

"How did it go?"

One of the two people at the front—a young man who still had peach fuzz on his face—answered in a soldier's clipped tone.

"We killed or captured them all. We took more casualties than expected because of a man named Huginn, but we joined forces with the Peace and Ares Guilds and subdued him. Then we dispelled the illusion magic around the area and notified the Korean government a little while ago. Oh, and Mr. Shu here played a major part."

"You've both worked hard. It would have been a difficult fight if you hadn't trusted us and helped."

At Team Leader Choi's heartfelt words, the man in his thirties whom the young man had called "Mr. Shu" shook his head.

"I only trusted the Übermensch's judgment and his choice. What I saw of him that day in Munich… He was a true superhuman."

When he looked my way, I gave him a small nod in greeting. I nodded to the young man beside him, too. He was watching me with an expectant look.

Joel Schumacher. Xiao Shen.

They'd owed me, and today they'd paid me back with interest.

The others probably had no idea that Joel Schumacher, who had politely declined to attend the inaugural ceremony because of his injuries in Munich, had secretly entered Korea.

Or that Xiao Shen had brought Hunters from the Public Security Armed Forces Department and joined the elite forces of the Peace and Ares Guilds, who were fully prepared.

I remembered a question Team Leader Choi had asked me a few days ago.

"There's a meticulous man. When do you think he's most vulnerable, Mr. Jin?"

The answer hadn't been hard. I'd seen it happen several times, and I'd made the same mistake myself.

"When he thinks he's succeeded."

I'd been right.

Michael Silbert might have guarded against things going wrong, but part of him had been certain he would win.

If he'd been acting like himself, he would have chosen France—his stronghold—or somewhere else with a firm support base, instead of Seoul, for the inaugural ceremony.

But that small lapse, that petty desire to stamp his name on this historic place, had brought down his vast ambition.

I could hear it clearly.

"We've won."

Along with Team Leader Choi's words, echoing through the silent air, someone's hideous ambition crumbled to pieces.

I knew what I had left to do.

…Yeah.

To end everything, I had to erase the starting line where it all began.

Just as we had executed the traitors here today, the people who would have stood in the way of the great war to come.

I had to pull out the root. Otherwise, new weeds—and offshoots of this thorn tree—would keep growing.

Michael Silbert.

Crack.

I stomped on the chest of the man lying at my feet. Bones shifted beneath my boot.

Michael Silbert came to, blood surging from his mouth. He looked around with bleary eyes.

"So… that's how it ended."

His voice was fading, but his tone was composed.

He had probably realized it instinctively the moment he looked around.

That Huginn, his right-hand man, and the private army he had spent so many years training would never make it here.

"Did you kill them all?"

I answered evenly.

"The ones who were going to die died. The ones who were going to live lived."

"Huginn must be among the latter. You'll have plenty to ask him."

"You know it."

"Then I have a favor to ask."

A favor.

That simple word suddenly made me sick. I kicked him in the face.

Thwack.

His head snapped aside, spraying blood.

But maybe he couldn't feel pain anymore. Without so much as a groan, Michael Silbert spat the blood filling his mouth and stubbornly continued.

"Tell Huginn I'm grateful for everything he's done, and that he no longer needs to be loyal to me. Grant me that favor, and it will be easier for both of you. You can at least spare yourselves a messy, tedious round of torture and interrogation."

"Is that a kindness for a retainer who's been loyal his whole life, or your last words?"

"Both, I suppose. From the look in your eyes, this place will be my grave soon."

I looked down at Michael Silbert as he smiled soundlessly.

And I knew, more certainly than ever, that I couldn't leave him the slightest chance.

The law? A trial?

Those institutions were made for humans, not monsters.

A monster should die like a monster.

So they could never struggle again. So that even the tiniest chance of the tumors he'd planted in this land over the past several decades saving that monster would disappear.

Yet this was also a lawful judgment.

Everyone here had witnessed the truth and fought through the bloodshed. They were witnesses and jurors, prosecutors and judges.

And from this moment on, they and I would finally become *us*.

Race. Sex. Age. Borders.

Even species would cease to divide us as we stood under one banner.

In the name of the World Hunter Federation.

Michael Silbert.

My voice broke the silence. Though I put no internal energy behind it, it carried through the chamber, clear and steady.

Loudly and clearly. On and on.

"From this moment forward, the World Hunter Federation revokes all your qualifications and summarily executes you as a traitor. Anyone who objects, step forward."

Team Leader Choi answered at once.

"No objections."

Magic Johnson spoke next.

"Everything according to the rules."

Prince Felix bowed with dignity instead of answering. Faye Chen and Chuck Hagel struck their weapons together.

Clang!

The deep note rang out over the ruins.

Others joined in. One weapon became dozens, then hundreds, striking together and throwing blue sparks.

Someone pounded his armor with his one remaining hand. A white-haired elder struck the ground with a bloodied cane.

Boom. Boom. Boom-boom-boom.

The world shook. Pooled blood splashed in every direction.

No one objected. Everyone agreed.

To the World Hunter Federation's first resolution.

To the death of a traitor born human who had become a monster.

Amid the deep resonance that rang on and on, I stared at Michael Silbert and asked,

"Any objections?"

After a moment's silence, he answered.

"None. At first, I fought with all my strength to survive. After that, I fought to get what I wanted."

"Any last words?"

"It's your turn now. Go on—struggle with everything you have. I'll be watching from up above."

I raised my spear as his mocking words reached me. The shaft felt heavier than it ever had before.

Then, in front of hundreds of pairs of eyes, I drove the spearhead down with all my strength.

Thrust!

The spearhead pierced straight through his throat.

A strangled sound failed to make it past his lips. Michael Silbert's body went rigid.

I looked into the monster's eyes as life quickly drained away, then delivered the last words I'd put off until now.

"Just like you said, watch closely. Not from up above—from the very bottom, beneath my feet."

"…!"

Was it anger that made his eyes widen at the end? Or the death he could no longer hold off?

Maybe both.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Countless chimes and radiance welled up inside me.

Chapter 787

“Ah.”

Jin Taekyung let out a single exclamation.

At that moment, he felt the full blessing of the supernatural power that had come to him.

Clear chimes, audible to him alone, rang without pause, while countless holographic windows rose above the ruins and filled his vision.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

You have defeated Lv. 175 Michael Silbert!
You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP and Fame!
You have achieved the rare feat Cut the Weeds and Pull Up the Roots!
We offer our unreserved praise for your bold decision to cut down the diseased grass and pull out its roots for the sake of the forest we all share.
But remember: the great fire that could consume the forest is more dangerous than any disease.
You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP and Fame as a reward for your achievement!
You have gained 20 points as a special bonus reward!
Level Up!
Level Up!
Most of your injuries and Stamina have been restored by the stacked effects of leveling up!
The special debuff Broken Body rejects the power of healing!

…

…

…

Countless notifications filled his eyes and ears.

At the same time, a warm radiance no one else could see or feel welled up from deep inside Jin Taekyung.

Whoosh.

Energy washed over him like a downpour—something that deserved to be called purification, not merely healing.

It enveloped the waste that had built up inside him, his damaged blood vessels and organs, his broken bones, and his torn skin.

Shhhhh.

The terrible pain throughout his body rapidly faded.

Beneath the sticky blood covering him from head to toe, wounds no one had noticed healed without a trace.

But none of that mattered to Jin Taekyung.

Not compared to the relief he felt.

It's over.

He let out the breath he'd been holding.

Michael Silbert lay dead, his eyes wide open. Jin could no longer sense any trace of life in him.

There was no doubt.

The bastard was dead.

More cunning than any enemy Jin had ever faced, the scheming man who had shaken him to his core had been born human and left this world a monster.

No. Perhaps by now his soul had tumbled into the abyss reflected in those staring eyes.

Just like Jin's final farewell to him, in the moment the cold spearhead pierced his throat.

"…Go to hell."

Jin spat out the words and gripped the spear shaft. He twisted it hard, cutting through the monster's neck.

Slash. Splash.

A jet of green blood erupted as Michael Silbert's head came free of his body and rolled across a pool of blood.

At the same moment, as if on cue, a tremendous roar erupted. No—it was both a roar and a cheer.

Boom! Boom-boom-boom!

Rumble!

The hundreds of surviving Hunters roared as one.

Their mana-charged shouts burst through the compressed air. Feet and weapons pounded the ground without pause, shaking the National Assembly building.

Some were simply overjoyed. Others trembled with anger that had yet to fade. Still others stared at them blankly and began to cry.

Jin Taekyung let the spear that had ended it all hang limply at his side.

"…Fuck."

What was the big deal? What the hell was so important about this?

He didn't know himself.

Why had the curse suddenly come out? Why was he crying like an idiot while everyone else celebrated?

But a voice at his ear supplied the answer.

“I don’t know what stupid thought is going through your head right now, but I’ll tell you one thing.”

The Skeleton King put a hand on Jin’s shoulder.

“The people who died aren’t your fault. I became a monster against my will, too.”

“…!”

“So stop bawling like an idiot. No one is blaming you or holding you responsible.”

Jin fell silent at those prickly but warm words.

Then, amid the endless cheering and rumbling, he let out a wry chuckle.

“Hey.”

“Hmm? Did you call?”

“Why are you acting all serious, you monster bastard?”

“…!”

“What are you looking at? Keep your eyes nice and polite.”

The Skeleton King had been quietly hoping for a response, though he’d tried not to show it. Now, he muttered with a stunned look on his face.

“Is this truly what human nature is like…?”

“I can hear you.”

“I meant you to.”

“A monster… talking back?”

“Ah, enough already!”

Teasing the Skeleton King—no, teasing his friend—was always fun.

Jin laughed at the Skeleton King’s fit of outrage, wiping his tears with his blood-soaked sleeve.

“And don’t think I missed you wiping your tears. It’s too late to hide it.”

“…You’re spreading lies, you bastard. When did I do that? Got proof?”

“No proof, but I’ve got witnesses. Plenty of people saw you besides me—huh?”

Grab.

Jin suddenly staggered. The Skeleton King caught him by the arm, his eyes widening.

“You…”

“Ah. The floor’s slippery with blood.”

Jin answered with a grin. But he couldn’t hide the tremble at the corners of his mouth or the crushing exhaustion in his half-closed eyes.

It was only natural.

Leveling up twice had healed most of his injuries. But everything that had happened on the way here, and the strain it had left on his mind, was more than a young man barely in his twenties could bear alone.

The sleepless nights and countless battles had begun the day he learned the truth about Michael Silbert's hideous nature and ambitions.

For the past few weeks, Jin had fought day and night.

And Michael Silbert and his countless monster hordes weren't the only enemies he'd faced.

There was the world's condemnation, growing harsher by the day. There were the disasters he'd heard about on the news from every corner of the world, and his own self-loathing at being powerless to stop those deaths.

Jin had fought himself, and he had fought the world.

Now that he'd finally defeated Michael Silbert, even standing still demanded superhuman patience.

But…

I can't.

He forced his drooping eyelids open.

Not yet. He had to hold on a little longer. Just a little longer.

Until he finished what he'd started.

Sirens had begun to mingle with the cheers, drawing closer. He couldn't collapse before he told the world the whole truth about what had happened here today.

No matter what.

Thud.

Using the spear he'd driven into the ground as a cane, Jin Taekyung leaned against it and murmured in a voice that seemed about to fade away.

"Thanks so fucking much, Assistant Hwang[3155], you son of a bitch…"

"Are you really all right…? Wait, what did you just say?"

"Hey, Golgoli."

"Huh?"

"You should use a spear too. Not a sword."

What? Out of nowhere?

The Skeleton King blinked, unable to make sense of it.

"Why?"

"Compared to a sword…"

"Compared to a sword."

"A spear…"

"A spear."

"Looks cooler."

"Looks coo—fuck."

[3155] *Jogyo* is a Korean term for an assistant instructor, including an assistant drill instructor in military training.

The Skeleton King sighed.

Why had he listened so closely to that inhuman bastard? Half of what Jin said was nonsense, and the other half was abuse directed at him.

I'm the idiot.

But the Skeleton King said nothing more. He only let out a long sigh.

He didn't want to wake his friend, who had fallen into a deep sleep as if he'd passed out, still leaning against the spear planted deep in the ground.

You've worked hard. Rest.

Perhaps everyone felt the same.

As if they'd never cheered at all, the hundreds of Hunters pressed their lips together in silence and simply looked on.

They watched the young man who had been braver and shone brighter than anyone else here today.

The superhuman who had stood against the whole world and kept to his path, even when the truth ahead was too dark to see through.

Could I have done what he did?

Each of them asked themselves the question and arrived at the same answer.

No one there could have.

They would have fallen, been scraped raw, battered and broken, and finally gone down, never to rise again.

But that young man, barely in his twenties—Jin Taekyung—had done it.

However many times he fell, he got back up. However badly he was battered and broken, he refused to stay down.

He alone had become a signpost and a light for those lost in the darkness.

The one who led everyone from the front.

The one who shared the pain of the wounded without ever yielding to weakness, who pressed bravely onward with an indomitable will.

And people had a word for someone like that, a word filled with all the reverence and love in the world.

Hero.

The moment that short word filled their minds, everyone there was overcome by a feeling they couldn't describe.

Hero. They knew the word all too well.

At some point, the whole world had begun calling them heroes. One ordinary day, they'd gained unexpected powers, fought monsters, and become humanity's sword and shield.

But why?

Why did that word, heard so often it had nearly worn grooves in their ears, make their hearts swell like this?

Why did looking back leave them both ashamed and choked with emotion?

One image kept coming back to them: the look in Jin's eyes as he shouted the truth without fear, surrounded by hundreds of weapons.

And the sight of a young man weeping alone, while everyone cheered at the end of the fierce battle.

Perhaps that was why the reinforcements entering the ruined National Assembly stopped without realizing it and held their breath.

And why, in a silence so deep it seemed you could hear a needle drop, someone let out the breath they'd been holding.

"Fuck."

People turned toward the voice and were surprised three times.

First, that anyone could deliver a curse in such a refined tone.

Second, that a curse could sound so awkward.

And finally, that the person who had managed both at once was the last man they'd expected.

Prince Felix paid their stares no mind.

No. He no longer cared.

"Fuck. Fuck. Fuck."

What a relief.

His pronunciation was still clumsy, but with each curse, something knotted in his chest seemed to loosen.

Felix found himself chuckling.

Damn it. What was so important about any of it?

Bloodline. Dignity. Appearances. Etiquette.

Everything he'd taken pride in for more than thirty years suddenly felt empty and burdensome.

He wanted to cast it all off, right then and there.

So he did.

For the first time in his life, he cursed like a dockworker and threw off the armor bearing the royal crest.

He wondered for a moment what expression His Majesty the King—his father—would wear if he saw him like this. But, well…

Did it matter?

Step. Step.

With everyone watching, Felix slowly crossed the ruined chamber and stopped.

Then he spoke without preamble.

"It looks as though you could use another pair of hands. If you don't mind, may I help?"

At Prince Felix's most courteous offer yet, the Skeleton King nodded. He was supporting Jin Taekyung, who had collapsed into sleep against the spear shaft.

"If you wish, then do so, human prince."

Felix's reply astonished everyone nearby.

"Please call me Felix, Mr. King. My friend."

"…!"

He gave the people staring at him a faint smile. As he took Jin by one shoulder, another hand reached out to help.

"You…"

"Watching from over there, it looked as though you still needed another pair of hands."

Choi Minwoo answered calmly, and more hands joined them.

One trembling hand belonged to Chuck Hagel, who was already acting as though he were going through withdrawal. The small hand covered in unusually thick calluses belonged to Faye Chen.

As for Magic Johnson, he stared at the staff in his hand for a moment, then suddenly grinned.

"Sometimes everything I've learned feels useless. Like right now."

He tucked the staff away and strode over to lend a hand.

At first glance, it made no sense.

A Grand Mage who had mastered hundreds of spells, and the finest Hunters, capable of slicing through several metric tons[3156] of concrete in an instant, had all gathered to lift one young man.

But this was how they chose to show him their respect.

Rustle. Rustle.

Only the soft brush of clothing broke the silence. Hands multiplied until there were hundreds of them, passing the sleeping young hero slowly overhead like a gentle ripple across a lake.

As carefully as if they were handling glass.

Careful not to disturb the peace that had finally found him, if only for a little while.

When they laid Jin down on the ground, everyone realized something.

The inaugural ceremony of the New World Hunter Federation, which would be recorded in the history of humanity, was not over yet.

The young man before them would be both the beginning and the end of the Great War to come.

Shing.

[3156] One metric ton is 1,000 kg, or about 2,205 lb (1.10 US tons).

The cold scrape of steel cut through the silence.

A sword slid slowly from its sheath and pointed toward the sky.

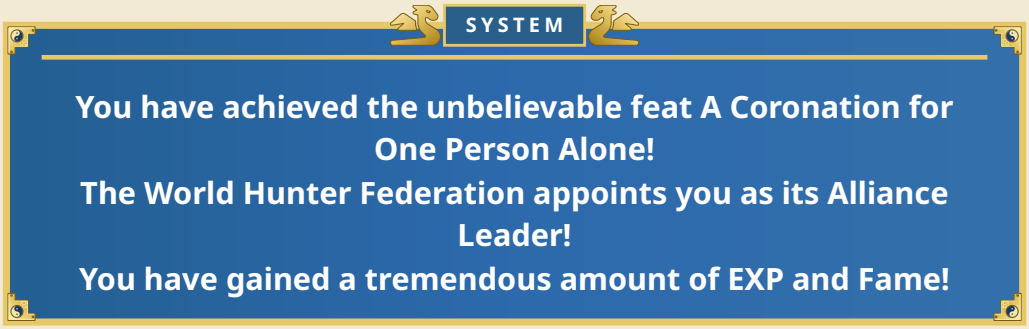
Soon, countless weapons—dozens, then hundreds—glinted in the sunset streaming through the shattered stained glass.

In the ruins, steeped in the reddish warmth of flames, they were turned toward the young man immersed in an unbreakable peace.

No.

Toward their new Alliance Leader.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



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...

The chimes, audible to just one person, rang clearer and louder than ever.

Loud enough to bring a smile to the lips of someone deep in sleep.

Loud enough to melt the guilt still lingering in a corner of his heart.

And so, at the end of a long and fierce day, a new page of history was turning.

Chapter 788

Paris, France. The Élysée Palace.

Despite the French fondness for fine food, President Emmanuel had finished a short, simple breakfast. Now he gazed at a box of cigars he had carefully stored away, overcome by memories.

At last, the day has come to take these out.

President Emmanuel had not smoked in twenty years.

In his youth, he'd been known as a cigar aficionado. But everything had changed after he met one man.

"I hear you like cigars."

"Ah, I enjoy one now and then as a hobby."

"Then that's quite an expensive hobby. Most people can't afford to spend over ten thousand euros a month sitting in their garden and burning grass."

"…!"

"You said you wanted to go into politics, didn't you? Then you'd be wise to cut back on the cigars. They're a monster that devours both your time and your health. And there's no easier target to tear apart than an extravagant politician from a family of businesspeople. Now, off you go."

His first meeting with the powerful man, arranged through his family's connections and enormous lobbying efforts, had ended just like that—with the absurdly simple advice to cut back on cigars.

But Emmanuel, a promising young lawyer, hadn't forgotten it.

As soon as he returned to his mansion, he threw every last one of his cigars—worth hundreds of thousands of euros—into the fireplace and began living a far more modest life.

A few years later, at Easter, he received a card bearing the image of two ravens.

> Congratulations on your rebirth.
> M. S.

That was how Emmanuel was chosen by Michael Silbert. The following year, he made a dazzling debut in French politics under the glare of the spotlight.

And after that?

What more was there to say?

Emmanuel rose faster than anyone.

It took barely a decade for him to become someone no political heavyweight—not even a prime minister or president—could treat lightly. Michael Silbert's shadow covered everything.

"Run in the next presidential election. You won't be the youngest president, but I'll help you make history as the longest-serving."

I'll help you.

At those words from Michael Silbert, Emmanuel—now a senator who embodied Paris and the leader of the largest party in parliament—had a sudden certainty.

The election was over before it had even begun.

He would be the next master of the Élysée Palace.

And at last, on the day that prediction came true, President Emmanuel mustered the courage to ask the benefactor who had come to see him:

"Why did you choose me, of all people?"

The answer was brief.

"You listened well."

"Pardon?"

"I want only one thing. Give me your absolute loyalty, just as you have until now. If I tell you to bark, bark. If I tell you to bite, bite. Don't repeat your predecessor's mistake, and I'll put not only enormous wealth and honor in your hands, but this entire country."

"…!"

"Will you be loyal to me?"

"No. I'll obey you."

Michael Silbert laughed aloud at that perfect answer and handed his new watchdog a box of cigars decorated with gold leaf.

"These are…"

"A gift. When my goal is realized, you'll be as good as a king. Save these cigars for that moment."

The memory of that day was still vivid.

As President Emmanuel gazed at the box and sank into thought, he felt his heart pound.

A king. A king.

A king in the twenty-first century—in this country obsessed with revolution, no less.

It was madness.

But when Michael Silbert said it, that was different. He was a man who had made countless impossibilities and wild imaginings come true.

President Emmanuel suddenly recalled the last words of his father, who had used the chaos of the Great Cataclysm to amass an astronomical fortune almost overnight.

"Everything that happens in this world is an investment and a deal. If someone wants something, give it to them freely. But always get back more than you gave."

People had despised his father, calling him the “Merchant of Death.” But even if he had gone to hell, he probably had no great regrets.

He must have watched his son make a better deal than anyone.

Young lawyer Emmanuel had given one man a loyalty bordering on obedience, and in return had become President Emmanuel.

Soon, he would possess power beyond the presidency—power so absolute that Emmanuel the First would hardly be too grand a name for him.

“Emmanuel the First…”

President Emmanuel murmured dreamily. Then the grandfather clock against the office wall chimed.

Dong. Dooong.

A bird and a dwarf popped out of the clock and spun around. Emmanuel checked where the hour hand pointed and blinked.

“Noon? Already?”

He must have lost track of time while reminiscing. He slowly tapped his desk.

It’s taking longer than I expected.

With the time difference between France and Korea, it was now eight in the evening in Seoul, where the World Hunter Federation’s inaugural ceremony would be underway.

He checked his smartphone just in case, but no word had come from the person he was waiting for.

Well, it would be strange if it ended early.

This wasn’t just any gathering. It was the World Hunter Federation’s first inaugural ceremony.

Given its importance to the future of global security, a meeting as long as a full marathon was hardly surprising.

Still, even with his unwavering faith in Michael Silbert, he couldn’t help feeling a little anxious.

Knock, knock.

President Emmanuel frowned at the sudden knock.

“What is it?”

An attendant’s voice came through the crack in the closed door.

“It’s time for your meal, Mr. President.”

“I don’t need it. And don’t let anyone near my office until I call for them myself. Understood?”

“Yes, I’ll pass that along.”

How could he have an appetite with the most important moment of his life just ahead?

President Emmanuel cursed inwardly at his dim-witted attendant, then stared down at the smartphone in his hand.

After hesitating, he tapped one person's number.

Brr. Brr. Brr.

The call rang on and on.

Emmanuel ran his hand over the cigar box, trying to suppress his anxiety. At last, there was a click, and someone answered.

"The ceremony—how did the inaugural ceremony go?"

The other person was silent for a moment before replying.

"It ended successfully."

The words he'd waited so long to hear.

Joy surged through Emmanuel, and he burst out laughing. He punched the air without realizing he'd clenched his fist and thanked the man who had given him the answer he wanted so badly.

"Thank you! Thank you so much! Huginn, you've worked so hard, too—!"

"Thank me? I'm the one who should be thanking you."

"What?"

At that moment, Emmanuel realized something.

The voice on the other end was deeper and rougher than usual.

And its owner wasn't in Seoul.

He was standing outside the door.

The price of realizing it too late was about to be paid.

Crash!

With a thunderous boom, the centuries-old office door burst into dust.

A massive man with graying hair strode through the opening and gave the frozen president a friendly smile.

"Long time no see, Emmanuel. You little rat—I could tear you apart and kill you, and it still wouldn't be enough."

"You—you're…"

"Funny, isn't it? A moment ago, I thought I could fall asleep in three seconds. But looking at your face has driven the tiredness right out of me. Johnson, who should be in Switzerland right now, probably feels the same way. Don't you think?"

Chuck Hagel laughed heartily.

He shoved Huginn's smartphone into his back pocket, then spoke to Emmanuel, who stood frozen like a statue. His voice was different now, deep and dark as an abyss.

"Michael Silbert is dead. By the hand of the new Alliance Leader we chose ourselves, in the name of the World Hunter Federation."

"…!"

"Now it's your choice. Get dragged out with your arms and legs broken, or walk out on those cotton-swab legs of yours."

It was over. All of it was over.

Everything he'd built, along with every future he could have had, had collapsed.

Faced with a reality he couldn't believe, he trembled, forgetting even to breathe. After turning it over in his mind again and again, he finally managed a word.

"C-cigar."

"What?"

"Could I smoke one cigar before I go?"

Chuck Hagel blinked, then let out a booming laugh.

"A cigar? Now that sounds good."

Then he drove a fist like a lump of iron straight into Emmanuel's face.

Wham! Crash!

Teeth and blood sprayed through the air. Emmanuel flew back like a cannonball, shattered the window, and disappeared from sight.

"Asshole. What kind of question was that?"

Chuck muttered and looked down through the broken window.

Dozens of Ares Guild members waiting below were pouring potions over the president who had fallen from the sky.

"Is he alive?"

"Ah, yes. He'll live."

"Good. Just keep him breathing."

"Understood. But, Mr. Hagel, where are we headed next?"

"Don't worry about that. Our mission is over."

"So we're heading straight back?"

"No. Wait a little. There's still something to do."

Chuck opened the cigar box sitting neatly on the table and smiled with satisfaction.

"Something very important. Mm."

A little while later, people drawn by the unexpected commotion saw their president being carried away, his body crushed, and pale smoke drifting out through the Élysée Palace's broken window.

But that was not the last shock awaiting them.

When they picked up their smartphones to report this unprecedented crime, an enormous bomb no one could have foreseen rocked the world.

> **Breaking News:** World Hunter Federation's first official announcement: "Two hours ago, we summarily executed Michael Silbert and his followers, who betrayed humanity. The operation is still ongoing."
>
> **Unprecedented bloodshed.** Choi, descendant of the Savior and interim spokesperson for the World Hunter Federation: "We will reveal the truth, along with all the evidence."
>
> **[Live] World Hunter Federation Official Press Conference**

The press conference began amid confusion and shock on a scale that "unprecedented" could hardly capture.

And even as Choi Minwoo calmly continued speaking before everyone, captured by hundreds of camera lenses, the key figures of the New World Hunter Federation spread across the globe like dandelion seeds on the wind, uprooting the weeds Michael Silbert had left behind.

One day. Two days. Three…

They were still at it on the day a young man finally woke from his deep sleep.

Chapter 789

It must have started a few years ago.

Before that, I could close my eyes anywhere, anytime, and fall asleep as if I'd passed out. Then the nightmares began.

In a way, it was only natural.

Even someone as thick-skinned as me would start to fall apart after crossing the line between life and death several times a week and watching people close to me die or get hurt.

This nightmare was no different.

But it was far calmer, sadder, and, in a way, even more welcome than the ones I usually had. Because I met people I missed inside it.

"Son. While Dad's at work, play nicely with Hayeon, okay?"

I heard my father's voice.

"Just call me hyung[3157]. Hyung[3158]."

"Whoa, we hit the jackpot with these Magic Gems today. Since we're on a roll, let's keep going till the end of the day, yeah?"

I saw the smiling faces of Cheonsu and the other team members who'd died in the Mutated Gate.

"It wasn't your fault. You did everything you could."

I got to stand beside Butler Kim once more as he struggled for breath and tried to comfort me.

Of course, if it had ended there, I wouldn't have called it a nightmare.

Even in my dream, I fought without stopping.

I cut down people who all looked the same and drove my spearhead into monsters' chests.

Then, amid blood that reached my thighs and corpses piled like mountains, I heard the screams of those I hadn't managed to save.

"Help me! There are people here! Please, at least save my child…"

I looked around. A hellscape stretched out on every side.

No—maybe it was hell itself.

A familiar face came into view, one more at home here than anyone else.

"This is a pleasant place, wouldn't you say?"

"Go fuck yourself."

I swung my spear as I answered.

Slash.

[3157] *Hyung* is a Korean term a male uses to address an older brother or an older male he is close to.

[3158] *Hyung* is a Korean term a male uses to address an older brother or an older male he is close to.

Michael Silbert's head flew into the air as he approached at a leisurely pace.

But the smile on his lips and the black gleam in his eyes didn't disappear.

"Take a good look at this scene we made together."

His headless body moved of its own accord.

Clap. Clap. Clap. The slow applause rang out, and I clenched my teeth. Flames erupted from my spear as I slashed diagonally downward, swallowing him whole.

Whoosh!

Michael Silbert's body, moving as though controlled by invisible strings, turned to ash and crumbled away.

But the flames weren't satisfied. They raced over the blood pooled everywhere.

Farther. On and on.

Fwoosh.

A great inferno rose, feeding on the blood and countless corpses like firewood, completing the hellscape.

The screams of those still alive rose higher than ever—then died away without a trace.

Everything was dead. Everything was burning.

The terrible sight before me was something beyond a dream.

I let my spear droop and stared blankly as the whole world went up in flames.

Then I heard a monster who had stubbornly survived even this calamity begin to speak.

"Please, survive until the end. Struggle with everything you have, every moment, until the very end of this world. That way, you can watch it all with your own eyes __"

Pop! Thud-thud.

I stomped down with all my strength, and his head burst like a watermelon.

But the silence I'd finally won wasn't an ending. It was the beginning of something new.

Crack. Crack.

The world shook with a deafening roar.

The sky split apart, and space warped in every direction.

At the same time, a single word flashed through my mind like a bolt of lightning.

Rift.

Rrrumble!

That was when it happened.

As my senses slowly faded, someone's distant shout caught hold of me and pulled me up from the depths of the nightmare.

"…ppa!"

Ppa?

"Oppa[3159]!"

"…!"

At that moment, radiant light filled my vision. I woke from the nightmare and finally saw Hayeon's face, drenched in tears for some reason.

After a brief but difficult deliberation, I greeted her with all sincerity.

"Don't cry. You're ugly enough as it is. If your makeup runs, it'll only get worse…"

Smack!

Ow.

I hurt, therefore I am.

I couldn't tell how the rest of that day passed.

Right after I woke up, Hayeon—having been hit with the hard truth—smacked my arm with a hand that stung just like Mom's.

Then she hugged me for the first time since kindergarten and burst into tears.

Mom had stepped away for a moment. When she came hurrying back… Well, there's no point going on. It'll only make my mouth tired.

She sobbed so bitterly that I thought I'd woken up in a morgue instead of a hospital room.

If the medical staff who'd been waiting nearby hadn't insisted she stop, I might have drowned in their tears. I'm only exaggerating a little.

"Um, could the family calm down for a moment? We need to run some tests first…"

Mom wouldn't have budged even if Demon King Asmodeus had come knocking—but a few words from a renowned doctor and healer were enough to make her step back without a fuss.

Of course, she made sure to clasp their hands and ask them again and again to look after me.

"Please take good care of my son. Check if anything's wrong with him. And there won't be any lasting effects, will there? My younger one said Taekyung started talking nonsense as soon as he woke up…"

"Nonsense?"

"Yes. I'm not sure exactly what he said. I'd stepped out for a moment."

"Understood. Patient, do you remember what you said?"

I answered.

"I told her not to cry because she'd look even uglier if her makeup ran."

"…"

[3159] *Oppa* is a Korean term a female uses to address an older brother or an older male she is close to.

“And it wasn’t nonsense. I almost closed my eyes again as soon as I opened them.”

“…”

“You may not know this, but once she takes off that makeup, it’s a disaster. You don’t have to go looking far for a Monster Wave.”

Hayeon glared at me as if she wanted to kill me. The medical staff listened with their mouths hanging open, then gathered in a corner of the room and started whispering.

“Is he all right?”

“Does he look all right to you?”

“Hard to say. His younger sister looks pretty, at least. Her makeup’s waterproof, so I don’t think it ran…”

“I can’t believe this. Is that what you’re worried about right now? Are you in your right mind? Who recommended you for this job?”

“I did. Sorry.”

“I’m sorry, Professor. What should we do?”

“Hmm. There doesn’t seem to be anything obviously wrong with his body, but the aftereffects could have affected his brain. Let’s run a full set of tests.”

“Yes. We’ll include a psychiatric evaluation.”

“…”

I’d told the truth, and they were treating me like a lunatic.

It was unfair, but there was nothing I could do. The fastest way to stop Mom from crying was to show her I was healthy.

Like I’d be sick.

But I swallowed that thought and cooperated with the healers and doctors.

Even after they’d put me through every test known to this world, I was forced to rest until the following day.

Two days.

It wasn’t a bad stretch.

Honestly, it was peaceful for once.

I was stuck in bed for two whole days without a smartphone or TV, all in the name of rest. But the people I cared about most were right there with me.

I ate, slept, laughed, and talked with my family. It felt like a dream.

If not for the nightmare I’d had just before waking up, those days would have been so happy I wouldn’t have felt a hint of anxiety.

But I already knew I couldn’t make them last any longer.

If I wanted to quiet the unease growing inside me, it was time to step back out into the world.

Mom and Hayeon. The medical staff. And all the friends who didn’t come to visit because they wanted me to rest.

They might have kept quiet about what was happening outside for my sake, but the System hadn't.

Alliance Leader, huh?

The System notifications I hadn't had a chance to check told me what had happened. Right after I'd finished Michael Silbert off for good, the World Hunter Federation had appointed me its new Alliance Leader while I was unconscious.

Never thought I'd end up as Alliance Leader, of all things.

I was surprised at first, but after thinking it over, I decided to accept.

It was their decision, but it was mine too.

I'd seen more than once what someone's ambition—what a hunger for power—could lead to.

Team Leader Choi or Magic Johnson would make a leader several times better than me. But if I was the one they'd chosen, I was willing to live up to their expectations, even if I still had a lot to learn.

I'll do the best I can.

Before that, though, there was one thing I had to take care of.

"Hayeon."

"Yeah?"

"You know Team Leader Choi's number, right?"

"No. Rest."

Her answer was immediate and firm.

Hayeon continued, her face set.

"Mom would be thrilled to hear that. Right?"

"Call him for me."

"…"

"There's something I need to take care of. Please."

At my earnest request, Hayeon bit her lip.

"Ugh, this is driving me crazy."

"Thanks."

"Are you crazy? Who said I'd call him for you?"

"You always bite your lip before agreeing to do me a favor."

"…"

Hayeon stared at me without a word, then let out a deep sigh.

That meant yes.

"The wind's cold."

That was the first thing Team Leader Choi said when I saw him after several days.

I was sitting alone on a bench. Glad to see him, I broke into a grin.

“How long has it been?”

“Today makes exactly one week since that day.”

“Must’ve been a busy week. In more ways than one.”

Team Leader Choi smiled back and joked, “Yes. While you were lying comfortably in bed, we were running around like mad.”

“You make me feel bad. Should I apologize?”

“No need. It’s one of the boss’s privileges. Though the press is desperate to find out how you’re doing.”

“Fair enough. They made a fuss last time, too. Now I’ve even got the title of Alliance Leader.”

Team Leader Choi paused at my calm response.

“You knew?”

“Yes.”

“That’s not quite the reaction I expected. Did your family tell you?”

“No. They wouldn’t even let me lift a finger.”

“Hmm. I wonder where the news leaked from. I told everyone to keep quiet so you could rest.”

“Who knows? I’ve got sources you don’t know about, too.”

Team Leader Choi studied me for a moment, then nodded without saying anything.

The gesture said he wouldn’t ask any more.

He already suspected I had secrets other people didn’t know about. To him, why I’d contacted him only two days after waking was probably the more important question.

“Things outside are going smoothly, despite what you may think. You could rest a little longer.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes. A week ago, we arrested a number of key figures with close ties to Michael Silbert. Among them…”

He rattled off names: French President Emmanuel, Swiss Interior Minister Werner, who was almost certain to become the next president, and the head of a massive corporation.

Every one of them was a heavyweight who held sway over politics and business around the world.

There were few Hunters among them. The ones who could have been called their leaders had either died alongside Michael Silbert that day or been captured.

“It was a bold and excellent decision. If you’d spared them, a much larger civil war would have broken out.”

Yes. That was exactly why we couldn’t let the bastards live.

The battle at the National Assembly had been a bloody bargain: their lives in exchange for tens, perhaps hundreds, of thousands of others.

But Team Leader Choi still hadn’t mentioned the one being I wanted to know about.

What had happened to the one person I was worried about. The source of this unease.

“Team Leader Choi.”

I looked up at the night sky, thick with stars. No—I looked at the information for the Main Quest, *Cataclysm*, still hanging there, and continued.

“Where is The Prophet?”

Chapter 790

"Where is The Prophet?"

At that single question, the smile on Team Leader Choi's lips faded.

Not *What happened to him?* but *Where is he?*

A man with a keen mind, he immediately grasped the simple but clear distinction.

And I already knew what the brief silence meant.

"You still haven't found him."

Team Leader Choi watched me with a grave expression, then nodded.

"That's right."

"You don't even know where he is?"

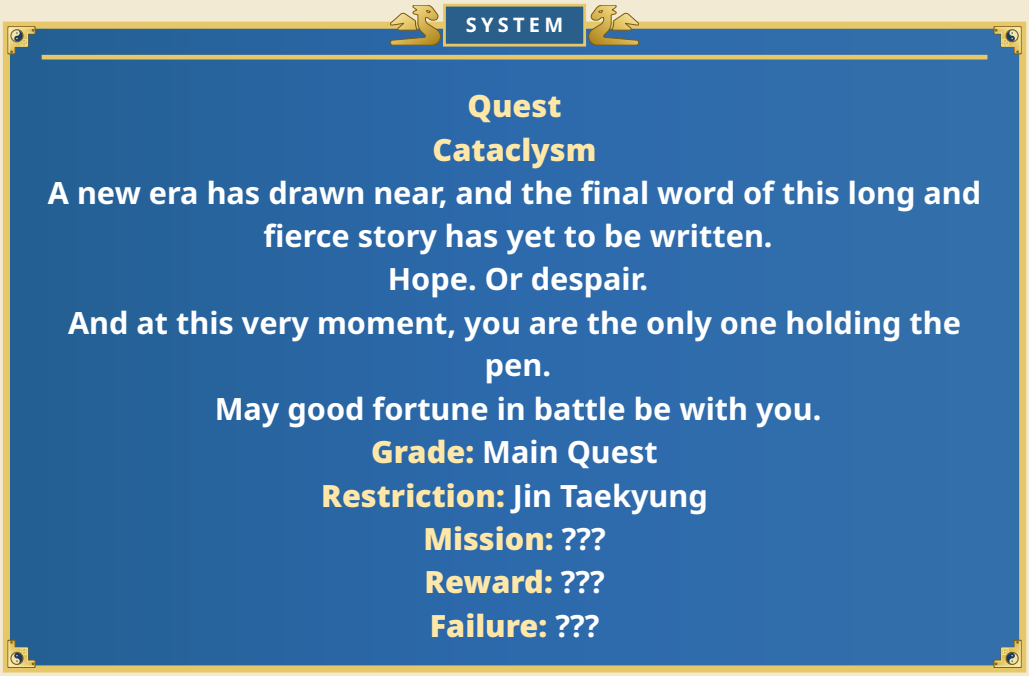
Team Leader Choi didn't answer. Silence was as good as a yes.

Damn it.

I swallowed the curse and looked up at the night sky.

Just because you're in the same place doesn't mean you're all looking in the same direction.

Just like Team Leader Choi and I were looking at different scenery at that very moment.



I stared at the holographic window covered in question marks and muttered to myself.

The Quest still isn't complete...

That could only mean one thing.

The being those question marks stood for had never been Michael Silbert.

Why? Why the hell?

I hadn't seen this coming. I'd been certain that eliminating Michael Silbert was the only way to complete the Quest and stop the coming Cataclysm.

But I'd been wrong. Completely wrong.

The Prophet.

That deranged fanatic who called himself God's messenger and a prophet—the terrorist I'd taken for a lackey following Michael Silbert's orders—was the real key to this Main Quest.

Or…

He was where the coming Cataclysm would begin.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Information for the Main Quest, Cataclysm, has been updated.
The mission has changed in accordance with your realization.
Mission: Eliminate The Prophet within the time limit (Incomplete).

New holographic windows filled my vision. At the same moment, I understood.

The clock on the bomb called Cataclysm, the one that would soon shake the world, was ticking even now.

These days, even "global village" sounded outdated.

More happened across the world in a single day than anyone could keep track of. People had grown used to seeing one shocking story after another on TV and the internet, then promptly forgetting them.

But what had happened a week ago had shaken even them.

Across the world, Hunters had launched armed crackdowns and arrests, sudden as land mines going off. Those caught up in them included high-ranking politicians—even presidents—some of the world's wealthiest people, and Hunters.

Every one of them was a heavyweight with influence over global politics, business, and security—not merely a particular region or country.

People waiting for the new World Hunter Federation's inaugural ceremony were thrown into confusion. Soon, confusion gave way to shock.

"The whole truth is in here."

Choi Minwoo stood before the cameras as interim spokesperson, holding a microchip smaller than a fingernail.

Of all the many cameras installed throughout the National Assembly to capture a moment in history, it was the only one to survive the aftermath of the tremendous battle.

It was also a Pandora's box, containing a truth no one could bear to face.

The footage ran for just over three hours. But once it was uploaded to a streaming site where the whole world could watch, it plunged the world into a pit of silence.

Choi Minwoo had told the truth. Everything was there.

No edits. No lies.

Only facts, plain and undeniable.

Billions of people were confronted with an unbelievable truth—and, within the Pandora's box that had suddenly opened, they discovered something still left inside.

Hope.

> └ One thing's for sure. I'd trust them with my family's lives.
>
> └ Agreed.
>
> └ Real heroes. Real Hunters.
>
> └ Yeah. And Jin's the greatest hero of them all.
>
> └ Damn it. What kind of idiot talked shit about that young savior?
>
> └ Hate to admit it, but I did until recently. I was an idiot. Call me a fucking moron and I couldn't argue.
>
> └ You bald piece of shit.
>
> └ Leave the bald part out before I put a bullet in your head.
>
> └ Fine, you fucking moron.
>
> └ God bless you.

> └ I've decided. I'm naming my unborn child Sibal.[3160] It's a great name, taken from Jin Taekyung's nickname.
>
> └ As a Korean passing by, I'd advise against that.

> └ Wait. Am I the only one who knows about that fucking monster? Why isn't anyone saying anything?
>
> └ If you mean the Stone-King, stop trying to derail the conversation and get lost.
>
> └ Are you insane? He's a monster.
>
> └ Oh. So?

[3160] "Sibal" sounds like *ssibal*, a common Korean profanity roughly equivalent to "fuck."

> ㄴ Listen. My cousin was shot and killed by a Black man, but I don’t treat my Black friends like murderers.
>
> ㄴ Michael Silbert killed countless people. The Stone-King fought for them. So which one’s the hero, and which one’s the monster?
>
> ㄴ Shit. Morons like you are going to be the end of the world.
>
> ㄴ Great. You done? Now get lost.
>
> ㄴ Goodbye, idiot.

> ㄴ I’m French, and at first I thought there’d been a terrorist attack. I was on social media when a video popped up of the president falling out of a window at the Élysée Palace.
>
> ㄴ Emmanuel? He deserved to die. The bastard was in bed with Michael Silbert.
>
> ㄴ Did you see the video of the Swiss interior minister getting arrested? Magic Johnson was beating him with that big, beautiful staff of his.
>
> ㄴ OMG…
>
> ㄴ Buddy. It’s not what you think. Don’t let your imagination run wild.
>
> ㄴ It was a swift, brilliant operation. The World Hunter Federation organized its forces in just an hour, then rooted out the traitors planted all over the world. They didn’t have time to run or fight back.
>
> ㄴ They kept the operation completely secret until it began, too. If this had been Mexico or Brazil, the information probably would’ve leaked through the gangs.

> ㄴ We support you and love you. May God watch over you all.
>
> ㄴ It’s too soon to relax. Nobody’s forgotten about the fanatical terrorist, right?
>
> ㄴ Of course we remember. But the World Hunter Federation will protect us. That lunatic who calls himself The Prophet is keeping his head down and watching what happens.
>
> ㄴ The attacks stopped two weeks ago. The Prophet will die soon, just like bin Laden, and then we’ll finally have real peace.
>
> ㄴ Jin. Please wake up soon. We’re waiting for our hero.

A week was nowhere near enough time for the world to recover from the shock. Even so, humanity was quickly finding its footing again, sustained by faith in the World Hunter Federation and hope that things would get better.

But somewhere beyond their sight, something new was already stirring.

Or perhaps a fire was starting—one that would swallow the world.

"Concentrate every force we can mobilize in the Middle East. Right now."

Choi Minwoo relayed Jin Taekyung's words straight to the World Hunter Federation's leadership. No one questioned them.

This wasn't a request. It was an order.

The first order from the Alliance Leader they had chosen.

And there had never been any doubt about their answer.

"Yes, boss."

The World Hunter Federation began to move.

"They're coming."

A trembling voice echoed through the cave.

The Prophet silently looked down at the man prostrate at their feet, then spoke.

"What is their estimated strength?"

"Th-that…"

"Answer."

The man hesitated, then pressed his head to the ground.

"We estimate at least a hundred thousand."

"…!"

"…!"

A hundred thousand.

The staggering number, far beyond what they had expected, froze the already chilly air in the cave.

Everyone gathered there knew those hundred thousand weren't ordinary infantry.

The World Hunter Federation.

Hunters were rare, whatever their rank. Only one person in a thousand had the chance to awaken, and even then, they had to undergo specific training before they could be recognized as a Hunter.

But their enemy was the World Hunter Federation.

True to its name, every Hunter in the world belonged to that vast organization. From humanity's billions, millions had beaten the 0.1 percent odds and been chosen by God. Now they were bearing down on the desert.

No—the whole world was coming.

"The entire desert is under surveillance."

"We've lost contact with our informants planted in the Pentagon."

"The residents of nearby villages and small towns are being evacuated."

"We have reports that the United States has moved an aircraft carrier…"

Their growing fear spilled into their voices. For a long while, they poured out everything they had learned. The situation was already hurtling toward the worst possible outcome.

A week ago, Michael Silbert's unexpected death had marked the beginning of their downfall.

The newly formed World Hunter Federation had moved boldly, without hesitation. It had begun by bathing its inaugural ceremony in blood, then set about gathering up the seeds Michael Silbert had sown. By revealing the whole truth without hiding or embellishing a thing, it had won support across the world.

Pure goodwill.

Nothing could stop the hammer the World Hunter Federation had brought down. A nation's president, the head of a corporation powerful enough to sway the world's stock markets—they had all fallen, bleeding.

Half a century ago, after Osama bin Laden's terrorist attack, Pakistan and other Middle Eastern countries had refused to let the United States cross their airspace. Even they would not dare oppose this operation.

They could hardly do something as insane as make enemies of the World Hunter Federation and the entire world. If they did, they would be met with artillery fire and a great many Hunters.

But unlike those who could choose to compromise, the people gathered in this cave had no choice at all.

"Prophet!"

"Please, please show us the way we must go!"

Desperate cries rang out from all sides.

Armed with fanaticism, they all knelt and prostrated themselves before one person alone.

They feared the enemy closing in. But they also held fast to their faith in the path they had walked: offering their lives to God, following the prophet He had sent, and witnessing the astounding miracles the Prophet had shown them.

"Teach these lost servants!"

"Defeat these infidels and proclaim God's will to the whole world!"

Fwoosh. Fwoosh.

The torches lighting the cave flickered in the wind. From beneath the Prophet's deeply drawn hood came a voice whose age and gender no one could place.

"As you wish, I shall carry out God's will and punish them. Inshallah.[3161]"

"O-oh…!"

"God is great!"

[3161] *Inshallah* is Arabic for "if God wills," commonly said when speaking of a hoped-for future event.

“Inshallah.[3162] Inshallah![3163]”

The anxiety that had threatened to burst gave way to cheers. As they cried out about God’s greatness and bowed again and again, the Prophet watched them and thought:

The long wait would soon bear fruit.

[3162] *Inshallah* is Arabic for “if God wills,” commonly said when speaking of a hoped-for future event.
[3163] *Inshallah* is Arabic for “if God wills,” commonly said when speaking of a hoped-for future event.

Chapter 791

As far as I knew, the Middle East mattered more to the world than most people realized.

Depending on how you defined it, it stretched from Western Asia to the countries of North Africa.

And since the Great Cataclysm, active resettlement policies had pushed its population past a staggering three hundred million.

That wasn't all.

The oil fields that had sustained the region were still doing their part, while Gates scattered throughout the area yielded Magic Gems—a resource that had rapidly overtaken oil in importance.

Of course, half the Magic Gems obtained that way probably disappear through back channels.

That was just how things worked around there.

There were no powerful civic groups or government agencies to investigate corruption, so even when resources came in, plenty leaked out the back.

In the Middle East, royal families held virtually unlimited wealth and power. Terrorist groups operated openly, and hypocrites who'd started as revolutionary leaders had evolved into dictators.

To them, the law was gum they could spit out whenever the flavor was gone.

Michael Silbert knew exactly how to exploit that.

Smuggling Magic Gems and leaving them unrefined were grave crimes under international law, but there were plenty of loopholes.

Especially in the Middle East and Africa, where terrorist groups and rebels were everywhere.

But a man who was already dead was no longer the problem.

It's the one who's still alive.

Tap.

I set down the tablet and rubbed my eyes. Staring at text for hours had worn me out.

Or maybe it was those three syllables I couldn't get out of my head.

The Prophet.

Thinking of someone whose face I didn't even know, I gazed out the window.

As the plane's wing cut across the cloud-choked sky and rain poured down, the voice I'd heard on TV seemed to rumble like thunder.

> “Following God’s will, we will not stop. Starting today, we will judge and punish you.”

Who was that bastard?

Even though the voice hadn’t been altered, I couldn’t make out their gender or age. Their face was hidden, too, beneath a hood pulled down low.

Did they cover up so carefully because people would recognize their face?

Probably, but even that wasn’t certain. The Prophet was as hard to make out as the storm clouds outside the window.

“The weather’s bad.”

A voice spoke beside me. Still looking out the window, I answered.

“It sure is. Doesn’t look like good flying weather at all.”

“It’s worse than that. This is about as bad as it gets.”

“Think The Prophet planted a mole at the weather service?”

“What makes you think that?”

“What do you mean? It’s the perfect setup for an assassination.”

Team Leader Choi dropped into the seat beside me.

“I can tell you two things. First, the airport forecast was accurate. This is just a change in the weather caused by magical power. Second, if I were The Prophet, I wouldn’t waste my time.”

“Why not?”

“Even if this plane crashed, you would survive, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“…Oh.”

“Wouldn’t you?”

“Who knows? I’ve never been in a plane crash.”

Even that was a ridiculous answer. A crash from this height, in weather like this, should obviously be fatal.

Team Leader Choi seemed to think so too. He shook his head, then glanced at the tablet on the table.

“Have you read it all?”

“Yes. Enough times to be sick of it.”

Some material had been added, but about half of it was already painfully familiar.

Before the World Hunter Federation was founded, I’d spent several nights reading those same documents over and over.

They concerned Michael Silbert, so naturally they covered The Prophet and the Middle East too.

“What do you make of them?”

“Hard to say. I can tell you at least three things.”

I glared at the tablet, crammed with text.

“The Middle East is damn huge, so finding The Prophet quickly will be tough. And that bastard is damn good at hiding.”

“And the third?”

“That fucking bastard has an enormous amount of unrefined Magic Gems.”

Right. That was the problem.

The Prophet had launched indiscriminate terrorist attacks around the world, then gone quiet after Michael Silbert’s death. The public figured they’d gotten scared and was starting to relax.

But that only made me more uneasy.

This mood. This calm before the storm.

They’re planning something bigger. I’m sure of it.

I’d been given a Main Quest unlike any before, one important enough for the System to name it *Cataclysm*.

That was why I’d mobilized the World Hunter Federation immediately.

Even after setting aside the personnel needed to prevent further terrorist attacks and monster waves, we’d sent a full hundred thousand troops to the Middle East.

Every one of them was a Hunter. That made for an enormous force.

Even Korea, recognized worldwide as a Hunter powerhouse, couldn’t mobilize that many Hunters, regardless of their individual levels.

Some people had murmured that we were deploying far too many troops right from the start, but that nonsense died as quickly as it started.

That was how much authority and power the World Hunter Federation held now.

The UN General Assembly, representing nearly every country on Earth, had given its approval. All of humanity supported us.

If the United States had *called itself* the world’s police, the World Hunter Federation was recognized as such by everyone—and untouchable.

Even Russia, which had clashed constantly with the Western powers led by the United States, had promised to cooperate fully with the Federation and warned the Middle Eastern countries that objected.

—If you don’t want to die, clear a path.

The diplomatic cable was long, but that was the gist.

Vladimir Furin, Russia’s president for life, was deeply upset that a terrorist attack had destroyed Red Square. He’d also been itching to settle the score with several Middle Eastern countries that had sided with Michael Silbert at the recent UN General Assembly.

So what choice did they have?

The Middle Eastern leaders hadn't been thrilled at the prospect of a hundred thousand Hunters showing up, but within a few hours they'd thrown open their airspace and territorial waters.

International condemnation was one thing. They might also find themselves drinking radioactive tea[3164] one sunny morning.

But the whole world's cooperation wouldn't make The Prophet fall into our hands on its own.

"How far has the search gotten?"

Team Leader Choi answered at once.

"Everyone is doing their best, but so far, no one has found anything unusual. The area is vast, and it's only been a day since the search began."

I knew. That was one of the main reasons I was heading to the Middle East myself.

Even so, I couldn't help asking again, even if it was premature.

"How long do you expect it to take?"

"In the worst case, more than sixty days. That estimate assumes we mobilize every Federation Hunter and all the allied forces that joined afterward."

"…Sixty days."

"Again, that's only the worst case. If we put everything we have into it, we may well finish sooner."

Would we, though?

I said nothing, but unease stirred inside me.

They're not going to be easy to deal with.

The Prophet had evaded surveillance around the world even before the Federation was founded.

The worst terrorist in history, far beyond the South American drug lords or even his much older predecessor, Osama bin Laden.

Some people might have thought it was amazing we could catch someone like that within two months…

I wasn't.

Two months is too late.

If my guess was right, The Prophet had an enormous quantity of Magic Gems. Unrefined, and therefore all the more dangerous—a ticking time bomb.

No one knew when it would go off.

In a month. In two weeks. Or…

It could be tomorrow.

And when that bomb went off, the Cataclysm named in my Main Quest would begin. It wasn't hard to imagine.

[3164] An allusion to the 2006 poisoning of Alexander Litvinenko in London with radioactive polonium-210 administered in tea.

If that happened, a disaster on par with—no, possibly even worse than—the terrorist attacks The Prophet had carried out so far would sweep across the world.

> "It's your turn now. Let's see you struggle with everything you've got. I'll be watching from up there."

A voice suddenly echoed in my ears.

Now I understood what Michael Silbert's last words had really meant.

But just as I'd sent that bastard, who'd seemed impossible to stop, plunging into the depths of hell, I was ready to fight again.

And I had a suspicion that was close to certainty.

The Prophet isn't ready yet, either.

A hungry person wouldn't hold back with a delicious meal right in front of them.

The Prophet probably hadn't finished preparing to set off the bomb. They were lying low, holding their breath so they wouldn't be found before the cooking was done.

I have to find them before that happens. No matter what.

I looked at Team Leader Choi.

"What about the cargo? Is it behaving?"

"The cargo? Oh."

Realizing what I meant, Team Leader Choi gave me a wry smile.

"It's been quiet. Though it does cause trouble now and then."

"Keep a close eye on it. We've got a mountain of things to find out about The Prophet."

"Understood."

I nodded and turned back to the window.

Through the distant, hazy storm clouds, a city shone brightly in the darkness. It was drawing closer.

The desert night was cold.

A young man handsome enough to draw admiring looks from anyone who saw him gazed up at the black sky and murmured.

"…I think something just passed by. Was that him?"

"What?"

"Nothing. Talking to myself. Anyway, where did we lose contact?"

Xiao Shen tilted his head at the Skeleton King's reaction, then answered.

"About thirty kilometers[3165] farther southeast, Mr. S."

"Mr. S… I thought I told you not to call me that."

"Oh. Sorry, Mr. King."

"…It still sounds strange, but I don't entirely mind it."

"Thank you!"

"Don't get excited, you young human brat."

He grumbled, but the Skeleton King was in a pretty good mood as he headed toward their destination—just as he'd said.

Actually, he was rather pleased.

That little kid isn't bothered by me?

Ever since his identity had been revealed, the Skeleton King had felt eyes following him wherever he went.

Some people watched him warily, if not with outright hostility. Others smiled and treated him with kindness.

Sometimes even curiosity, depending on the kind, was a burden.

That was why the Skeleton King had chosen to conduct his search alone. Being alone was easier. It gave him a chance to escape all those eyes, if only for a while.

But this little brat from China had joined him without a second thought and stayed with him ever since.

That devious human said the only good Chink was a dead Chink. Looks like there are exceptions, even if they're rare.

Smiling to himself, the Skeleton King arrived at their destination with Xiao Shen.

It was a patch of sparse woods and desert where a search squad had lost contact an hour earlier.

"This the place?"

"Yes. No doubt about it, Mr. King."

"I don't see anything around here. Are you sure—"

The Skeleton King had been frowning as he surveyed the area, but his eyes suddenly flew open.

"…What's that?"

[3165]Thirty kilometers is about 18.6 mi.

Chapter 792

"…What's that?"

Xiao Shen turned at the words but saw nothing unusual. The Skeleton King did.

Even though Magic Johnson's illusion magic had given him a human appearance, he was fundamentally a monster.

And not just any monster—one of the highest-ranking undead.

The sensation gripping the Skeleton King at that moment was something connected to the very source of his power.

Damn it. This is…

There was no doubt.

The feeling was faint, but unmistakable.

Beneath a dark sky that swallowed even the moonlight, he sensed the energy of death scattering across the endless desert.

There wasn't a single drop of blood or a corpse in sight, but the Skeleton King recognized the energy stirring his instincts from beyond the darkness: death qi.

He knew, too, what had happened to the search squad that had suddenly gone silent about an hour ago.

"Young human brat."

"Yes?"

"Contact the main force. Tell them we found the search squad."

"…!"

The desert was still, without a trace of anyone. But the Skeleton King's words were the opposite of reassuring.

Xiao Shen finally understood what was happening. His face stiffened as he nodded, and the Skeleton King started walking, following his instincts.

Crunch. Crunch.

His feet left prints in the sand, grains crumbling beneath each step.

After about ten paces, he stopped and muttered, "Whoever did this buried them deep."

The next moment—

Fwoosh!

A section of the desert, stretching out like an endless sea, surged into the air.

With a single gesture, the Skeleton King sent out a vast surge of magical power that held the sand aloft. Beneath it lay twenty bodies. At the sight of them, he froze.

"…!"

A recent memory flashed through his mind, bringing an ominous premonition with it.

Wait. Then could it be…

His thoughts went no further. They couldn't.

Whoosh.

A chill wind blew in from somewhere, sweeping sand through the air.

Something else was carried in it.

The Skeleton King stared into a distant stretch of pitch-black desert, then turned to Xiao Shen, who had noticed nothing yet.

"Have you contacted the main force?"

"Yes. They said they're sending the support team stationed nearby right away…"

"How long?"

"Thirty minutes at most."

"Thirty minutes. That's awkward."

He clicked his tongue.

"I'm not sure I can protect anyone."

"…?"

"Hmm."

He looked Xiao Shen up and down. Then, with a sigh, he said, "Listen, young human brat. I'm giving you two missions."

"Ah, yes! I'll do anything you ask, Teacher King."

"Good attitude. First, take out that damned special radio of yours and contact the main force again."

"What should I tell them?"

"Send the most capable humans they have, as fast as they can. Not some weak support team riding in on turtles. Got it?"

Xiao Shen didn't know why recovering the bodies called for such speed or so many capable people, but he nodded without hesitation. The person he respected most in the world was Jin Taekyung, and the Skeleton King was Jin Taekyung's friend.

"Understood. What's the second mission?"

Even Xiao Shen had to ask again when he heard the answer.

"Pick up a weapon."

"What?"

"And protect yourself. If you don't think you can, you can run."

"W-wait a second."

What was that supposed to mean?

Xiao Shen blinked at the baffling order. He understood soon enough.

Rrrumble. Rrrumble.

An unfamiliar tremor traveled through the ground. It grew stronger, sending countless grains of sand bouncing into the air all around them.

Then the Skeleton King spoke, turning Xiao Shen's suspicion into certainty.

"Quite a crowd."

"…!"

Xiao Shen didn't answer. He stood with his mouth open, staring at the distant horizon. In his eyes, the darkness writhed like a living thing.

No. Those were monsters, too many to count.

Monster Wave…!

At the moment the words that had become humanity's nightmare struck Xiao Shen's mind—

Crunch.

The Skeleton King walked toward the rapidly approaching tide of monsters.

There was no fear or hesitation in his steps. Mighty magical power surged from him, reaching farther and farther across the desert.

"In the name of the King, I command you."

His low voice echoed across the desert. It pierced the thick darkness and roused the spirits crushed beneath the weight of ages and countless grains of sand.

"Answer the call."

Rrrumble!

A tremor like an earthquake swept through the desert.

At their king's call, steeped in the energy of death, spirits that had lain in deep slumber burst through the sand and rose to the surface.

Crackle!

Pale sand scattered. White bones gleamed in the darkness.

Grrr.

An Arabian leopard, its beautiful hide lost in death, stretched. Above wolves and hyenas whose eyes shone green, dozens of eagles spread wings stripped down to bone and soared into the air.

Eeeee!

Their sharp cries split the night. With wings spanning several meters,[3166] the eagles glided high overhead.

They flew past the monster army charging across the ground in a storm of sand, then scattered over the vast desert and woods. They had only one mission:

Find a certain being who wasn't here, by the King's command.

"Somewhere in this desert, there's something with the scent of humans on it. Find it. Without fail."

[3166] One meter is about 3.28 ft; several meters is several yards.

The eagles beat their wings vigorously.

They had magical power to carry them on the wind instead of feathers, and though they'd lost the life within them, their vitality would never run dry.

Whoosh!

Far below, the King watched the flock disappear into the distance. He thought of the human bodies he had uncovered moments ago, then walked toward the monster army bearing down on him.

What kind of trace was it?

Whoosh—BOOM!

A vast surge of magical power burst from his outstretched fist and swallowed the monsters at the front. A hundred or so beasts rushed into the gap it left, tearing into the enemy.

Yowww!

Smack!

A swipe of the leopard's forepaw sent an Orc's upper body flying. A pack of hyenas nimbly dodged a club falling toward their heads, then sank their teeth into a Troll's body.

Crunch!

The living monsters outnumbered them beyond comparison.

But as soon as the battle began, the Skeleton King understood. Absorbing part of Michael Silbert's magical power had strengthened his powers enough to let even these spirits, once mere wild animals, crush ordinary monsters in an instant.

Splatter! Crunch!

Graaaah!

Blood and flesh flew. The living screamed.

The enemy formation began to crumble in moments.

With a single strike, the Skeleton King knocked the heads off three ogres. Then he looked toward a dark stretch of desert.

He couldn't see anything, but he knew. Whatever had killed the search squad had already left and vanished somewhere out there.

What the hell are you?

The question he asked himself went unanswered. The Skeleton King stared into the darkness with sunken eyes, then raised an ogre lying like a rotten log from the dead.

No—not just the ogre. Everything around him.

"Answer the call."

Fwoosh.

A dazzling golden radiance spread in every direction, so bright it was hard to believe it was magical power.

The undying army, now twice its former size, fell upon the living.

BOOM!

Grrrrr!

The desert was gradually buried beneath countless screams and death.

Xiao Shen stared blankly at the scene before remembering the mission he'd forgotten.

"Base. Base, respond."

Chhh.

Static hissed from the radio enchanted with communication magic as it sent out a mana-laced signal. The signal pushed through the unstable magical power permeating the air, traveling farther and farther.

And when Xiao Shen's urgent transmission finally reached the main force—

"Company, halt!"

An aircraft carrying someone landed smoothly on the runway, between ranks of soldiers and Hunters standing in flawless formation.

This operation involved a hundred thousand Hunters and a coalition of nations from across the world. It was massive—less an operation than a war.

Plenty of Hunters remained at the main base, and there were so many soldiers you could hardly take a step without running into one. An army of different nations and races.

The World Hunter Federation had to choose its commander at the base carefully, in case the chain of command broke down. Team Leader Choi, an excellent adviser, recommended someone.

A man with extraordinary strength and a distinguished record as a Hunter, along with the strategy and knowledge to command a large army.

A Hunter and a soldier. The only man to have reached the top of both professions.

Chuck Hagel—an S-rank Hunter active since the Great Cataclysm and the former Secretary of Defense of the good ol' U.S. of A.

"Oh. Sleeping Beauty finally showed up. Or were you hibernating?"

Chuck Hagel's idea of a greeting drew quiet laughter from the people lined up on either side of me.

It vanished without a trace the next moment.

"You're laughing? Does this fucked-up wartime situation look like a joke to you?"

"…"

"You lunatics. From now on, anyone who laughs in front of me is getting their ass kicked, rank be damned. I don't care if you're some pasty Yankee dumbass who thinks white skin is your greatest achievement in life, a darkie spouting bullshit

about political correctness, or a yellow monkey who can’t stop staring at his smartphone. I’ll beat every last one of you half to death. Understood?”

“Yes, sir!”

“Goddamn it. I can’t hear you!”

“Yes!! Sir!!”

Only after everyone shouted at the top of their lungs did Chuck Hagel nod and take a drag from his cigar.

“Okay, ladies.”

“…”

Holy shit. The man had presence.

He really was a living legend. Even Senior Kim Soodan would have to concede he had a thing or two to learn from Hagel about taking over a stage.

Of course, those thick arms like a bear’s and the violence he was born with had a lot to do with creating this brisk atmosphere.

He’s definitely the right man for the job.

Just as I thought that, a military jeep came tearing across the runway and screeched to a stop in front of us. A soldier in dress uniform hurriedly called out.

“Monster Wave! We’ve received an emergency request for support. It’s a Monster Wave!”

If I’d been an ordinary traveler, I would’ve taken a day to recover from jet lag.

But my life had parted ways with the word *ordinary* a long time ago, and there was no chance of them ever getting back together.

“Where is it?”

Chapter 793

With the whole world searching high and low, the chances that The Prophet had slipped into a major city full of people were close to zero.

So the tight search net spread across the Middle East, centered on the main force, was focused on monitoring underdeveloped areas. The place we headed to right away was no exception.

Wasteland stretched out on either side of a track so rough it hardly deserved to be called a road.

Beyond it lay a desert as vast as the open sea, dotted with little stands of trees like reefs.

And there, familiar faces were waiting for me.

“You’re with the main force, righ—huh?”

Surprise flashed across a face so young it belonged more to a boy than a man. Xiao Shen stared at me, dumbstruck, then cried out.

“Mr. Jin!”

“Damn it. Why does that Chinese kid have to be so loud?”

Chuck Hagel had come along in Team Leader Choi’s place in case anything happened. He let out a deep sigh.

“Do me a favor. Can’t you do something about that kid? Every time I see him, all he talks about is you. My ears are starting to hurt.”

“Well, he is pretty attached to me.”

“There’s attached, and then there’s that. Wilson wasn’t even that bad.”

“Who’s Wilson?”

“My dog. Whenever I came home after a few days away, he’d charge at me like a maniac. Must’ve thought I was an intruder.”

“Maybe Wilson just had a bad temper?”

“He died three years ago. It was summer.”

“…”

Shit. He’d played two cheat cards at once.

The Talullah[3167] moment and the summertime sentimentality hit me so hard I could barely breathe. By comparison, I was glad to see Xiao Shen, who’d just sprinted over like a track athlete.

“H-how could someone as shabby as Mr. Jin come all the way to a place this precious?”

“You’ve got that backward.”

“Oh.”

[3167] Talullah is a Korean internet meme about awkwardly backpedaling after unwittingly insulting someone’s loved one.

I patted the statue-like Xiao Shen on the shoulder, then looked around.

The place was definitely shabby.

Sticky blood and a foul stench covered everything.

As I gazed at a pool of blood the size of a small lake, a familiar voice reached me.

“You’re slow as hell. What took you so long?”

I turned. A figure was walking out of the darkness, countless pairs of monster eyes gleaming eerily behind him.

Shing.

Dozens of Hunters accompanying us as our supposed entourage reflexively drew their weapons. I stopped them with a casual wave and answered evenly.

“I got here as fast as I could.”

“Already talking nonsense. I’ve been waiting at least a week.”

“Well, I did sleep for a long time.”

“So you dumped this great king in a shithole like this while you rested without a care?”

“More or less.”

“Damn it.”

Scuff. Scuff.

For all his grumbling, he couldn’t hide the pleasure on his face as he drew closer.

I greeted the Skeleton King for the first time in a week.

“You’re still alive.”

“I am. Though I died a long time ago.”

They say even a dog can learn to recite poetry after three years at a village school.

I gave a quiet laugh at the Skeleton King’s practiced retort.

Behind him stood an army of well over a thousand monsters, even by a rough count.

Though, technically, it was an army of the undead.

“Looks like you’ve more or less finished up. What about the rest?”

“There are none. I took care of every last one.”

I nodded. If the Skeleton King said so, then that was that.

Even Michael Silbert, who’d kept his identity completely hidden by controlling the two energies coexisting inside him, had once aroused the Skeleton King’s suspicions. Whether he wanted the role or not, the Skeleton King was a monster—and when it came to magical power, he was the foremost expert.

And his abilities are exceptional.

In Murim, a Supreme Peak master is called a one-man army.

An S-rank Hunter in the modern world might not compare to a Supreme Peak master, of course, but they weren’t treated all that differently.

Each was a superhuman operating on a different level from ordinary people and Hunters.

Even among such people, the Skeleton King's abilities stood out.

Any capable S-rank Hunter could take down an army of monsters alone. Finishing the job in less than thirty minutes without a single casualty was another matter.

"So that's *i-mon-je-mon*—monsters against monsters.[3168]"

"*I-mon-je-mon*? What are you talking about?"

"You don't know the four-character idiom? Passed down to us by our wise ancestors…"

"I have no need for it. I'm a citizen of the great United States of America."

"If I remember right, just a few months ago you read 'alligator' as 'arigatou.'[3169]"

"I'm Japanese American."

"…"

"Konnichiwa.[3170]"

Is this guy fucking insane?

I stared at the Skeleton King, who could swap out his family tree at the drop of a hat, with some bemusement. But I didn't have much to say. He'd held off a Monster Wave by himself. The least I could do was praise him instead of cursing him out.

I sighed and started to turn away. Then a question occurred to me.

Why did he call for backup?

The Skeleton King was powerful. As long as his magical power held out, he could create an endless army of the undead, and his own fighting ability was no joke.

So why?

Just to protect Xiao Shen?

Or…

Was there something else?

I turned back. Maybe my thoughts showed on my face, because the Skeleton King was watching me with a subdued look I hadn't seen a moment ago.

"What?"

"Hmm."

"What is it?"

After a brief silence, he answered.

"Even this great king doesn't know."

"What?"

[3168] *I-mon-je-mon* twists a Korean four-character idiom about using one enemy against another, replacing part of it with "monster."

[3169] *Arigatou* is Japanese for "thank you."

[3170] *Konnichiwa* is a Japanese greeting meaning "hello."

“I couldn’t work out what did it, or how it was possible, no matter how much I thought about it. I tried to find it, but it had already vanished without a trace.”

“What do you mean, ‘it’? What the hell are you talking ab—”

“You’ll understand when you see it. You’ll remember, too.”

Remember what?

Before I could make sense of it, the Skeleton King gave an order.

“Bring them here.”

Thud. Thud.

At his gesture, three headless undead ogres approached with heavy steps. Then, with a care that seemed impossible for creatures their size, they set down what they were carrying.

The moment I saw the twenty bodies of people who had once been human, I understood what the Skeleton King meant.

“…Fuck.”

The curse escaped through my clenched teeth like a groan, mingling with the cool desert air.

Chuck Hagel came over to inspect the bodies. The cigar fell from his mouth.

“Holy shit.”

He wasn’t the only one.

“What the hell is this…?”

“Damn it. Henry?”

Shocked cries and curses broke out all around us. Those who made no sound simply stood there, stunned.

Was it because the bodies had been so horribly mutilated?

No.

The other Hunters and I had seen countless horrific sights. On a battlefield reeking of monsters and blood, even a severed limb wouldn’t make us bat an eye.

But even people like us had never seen anyone die like this before.

Almost none. A handful of us, myself included, had.

“Fuck. Jin, is this…?”

“Yes.”

I kept my voice as calm as I could.

Moonlight spilled through gaps in the slowly parting clouds. Beneath it lay twenty bodies drained of all vitality, their skin and bones shriveled like mummies.

I thought of someone who’d died the same way only a month ago, in an unnamed hideout.

“Siegfried Bassmann.”

One of humanity's three great Grand Mages. Or rather, one of the three who *had* been.

Whatever had killed him was here in this desert.

Ding!

The distance to the site and back was the same, but the return trip felt incomparably shorter.

My head was full of questions.

How?

It wasn't just me. Everyone had been certain Michael Silbert killed Siegfried Bassmann.

The reason was simple.

Bassmann was a Grand Mage, but unlike Magic Johnson, a War Mage who specialized in combat magic, he was a scholar through and through. That was why Johnson had suspected him of designing Area A. Bassmann was a master of barrier magic based on Magic Formations, as well as an expert on monsters.

Would a mage that skilled—and that reclusive—have protected his hideout with nothing but a tarp?

Like Area A, his hideout had been concealed behind all kinds of barriers. Only a handful of people in the world were strong enough to break through those spells.

And of that handful, Michael Silbert was the only one who'd wanted Bassmann dead.

But…

We got it wrong.

I knew it the moment I saw the bodies.

I'd been wrong. We all had.

At least on the day Siegfried Bassmann died, Michael Silbert hadn't been the one to visit the Grand Mage's hideout.

If Michael had killed him, the Quest window still occupying a corner of my vision should have disappeared long ago.

SYSTEM

Quest
An Unknown Death
The reclusive Grand Mage, Siegfried Bassmann, has died for unknown reasons.
But everything has a cause.
Discover how he died and who killed him.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Discover the truth behind his death (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

The System wasn't all-powerful.

It gave me a vague direction to follow, but it never told me how far I was from my destination or what traps lay along the way.

That was probably why I hadn't noticed anything strange about this Quest, even when I checked my System messages and Quest windows right after waking up.

I'd simply assumed it was still open because I hadn't gotten the full truth about Bassmann's death out of Michael Silbert.

To me, the Cataclysm Main Quest was the root I had to pull out right away. Everything else was just a branch.

That had been my crucial mistake.

Branches and roots served different purposes, but they were parts of the same tree. Follow a root upward and you reached a branch. Trace a branch down and you reached the root hidden deep underground.

I just hadn't uncovered it yet. Even if it was hidden now, I could find it someday.

And in that sense, the first person I went to see after returning to the main force was one of the largest branches on the sick tree that was Michael Silbert.

"Someone died about two hours ago. Not just one person—twenty."

A faint smile crossed the gaunt face on the other side of the table as soon as I sat down and said it.

"You're impatient. You've invited a guest here—can't he at least have a cup of coffee?"

Coffee. A smile. A guest.

I licked my parched lips.

Strangely, I wasn't angry. No—maybe I'd reached the limit of my patience the moment we began.

“I’m going to ask you one thing. Listen carefully and answer me, you crow bastard.”

Huginn froze under my killing intent. I put into words the question that hadn’t left my mind the entire way back.

“Did The Prophet kill Siegfried Bassmann?”

Chapter 794

“Did The Prophet kill Siegfried Bassmann?”

Huginn clamped his mouth shut at the killing intent in my voice. Just as he had for the past week. Just as he would forever, it seemed.

But unlike the investigators who’d interrogated him so far, I had no intention of backing down.

No matter what it took.

“What do you think of this room? Nice atmosphere, don’t you think?”

At my sudden question, Huginn’s eyebrow twitched.

I stood and slowly paced around the spacious room, furnished with nothing but a table and chairs.

“No cameras running twenty-four hours a day, no observation window. Must feel like paradise to a prisoner, right? I went through something similar once, so I know how awful it feels to be watched every second.”

“…”

“That’s why I brought you here. I thought it’d be more convenient for both of us. Like I said, no prying eyes, and…”

I dropped back into my seat with a thump. “The soundproofing magic is perfect, too.”

He didn’t answer, but I knew.

The look in his sunken eyes told me he’d understood exactly what I meant.

After a brief silence, a snicker slipped between Huginn’s lips.

Pfft.

The breathy sound grew louder until his laughter rang through the room. His shoulders shook for a long while before he finally spoke.

“Is that all?”

“What?”

“I asked if that’s all you’ve got. Torture, threats—whatever you’re going to do, do it properly. That isn’t even worth laughing at.”

This time it was my turn to keep my mouth shut. Huginn took the baton, his face full of scorn.

“You won’t get the answer you want from me, no matter what you try. Just like those bastards who came before you.”

Those bastards who came before me.

So that was why he’d grown so gaunt since I last saw him. Apparently, I wasn’t the first visitor.

Of course, I’d more or less guessed as much.

A bunch of countries could join forces, form the UN, and draft an international convention against torture. In the end, if no one found out, what did it matter?

And Huginn had been Michael Silbert's right hand, handling missions both big and small.

A traitor to humanity who held a vital secret had locked his lips tight. The American torturers seasoned in the Middle East had probably put their skills to work while the leadership looked the other way.

And every one of them failed.

I studied Huginn after his outburst.

His mana was suppressed and his entire body bound, but he was still an S-rank Hunter. More than that, he was an exceptional fighter chosen to be Michael Silbert's right hand.

Even torture and mental magic would struggle to break his will.

"Just talk and it'll all be over. Like the others who were captured with you, all you have to do is tell the truth."

"Go fuck yourself."

"Michael Silbert left you a final message, didn't he? You've heard it by now."

"I have. But this is entirely my choice. Ever since I was five—"

"Shut up. I don't want to hear it. I don't care if you were a piano prodigy at five or an orphan who grew to hate the world."

Everyone had their sob story.

But I wasn't some late-night radio host, and I had no reason to listen to a villain's tired old backstory.

I did know what he wanted most right now, though.

"If you tell the truth, I'll promise you one thing."

"A promise?"

"Yeah. A promise."

"Then you won't get an answer. I don't need any—"

I cut off his scornful reply with the one line I'd prepared.

"I'll kill you."

"…!"

"As painlessly as possible. Cleanly. I can't promise to let you go—I couldn't keep that promise. But I can do this today."

"You bastard…"

"Don't deny it. You'd rather die than keep living like this, wouldn't you?"

He tried to hide it, but I could see it.

Resignation and spite mingled in his eyes as they began to waver. His tongue, though, still refused to swallow his pride.

"Cut the bullshit. There's no way you can make me talk."

“From what you’ve been saying, you definitely know something.”

“…”

“By the way, how old are you now? Around fifty, if I remember right… Still young. You’ve got a long life ahead of you.”

In Murim, fifty was old enough to be called a grandfather without anyone batting an eye. But in the modern world, fifty was still the prime of life.

Plenty of people with money lived past a hundred thanks to cutting-edge medicine and magical health care.

And Huginn was an S-rank Hunter. Even with his mana suppressed, his vitality was on a completely different level from an ordinary person’s.

“Our crow friend’s going to live a long time. Of course, he’ll spend the rest of it in prison.”

I leaned my chair way back and gazed at the pure white ceiling, my voice calm as I went on.

“A sealed room without a ray of sunlight. Someone watching you around the clock. Interrogations whenever they feel like it. Or should I say torture? After everything you’ve done, they’ll probably be pretty brutal for a long time.”

“…”

“You’ve been tough enough to make it this far, somehow… But what happens when it goes on for fifty years? Well, at least you’ll stay healthy. They’ll shower you with potions after every round of cutting.”

Millions had been killed or injured in the terrorist attacks.

In front of a humanity consumed by grief and rage, the word *human rights* had already become meaningless.

If an article appeared in the *New York Times* tomorrow morning saying Huginn had been tortured, people all over the world would be shocked—and start collecting donations.

Not for his legal fees. For potions to prolong his suffering forever.

And as time crawled by, Huginn’s mind would slowly fall apart.

Or maybe it had already begun to crack.

“Team Leader Choi told me something interesting on the way here. Apparently, you caused a bit of a commotion on the plane. Are you sick? Or was it a seizure?”

Probably the latter.

Pain was the same for everyone, even an S-rank Hunter with a strong body and mind. He just knew how to endure it.

Getting used to pain didn’t make it hurt less.

“Why aren’t you answering? You’re making me feel awkward for asking. If you’re already like this, how are you going to get through the rest of your life?”

Just as I straightened from my half-reclined position, a wet crunch sounded and blood poured from Huginn's mouth.

He'd bitten his tongue.

"Ouch. That must hurt."

I clicked my tongue, pulled a potion from my Inventory, and shoved it into Huginn's mouth. The bleeding stopped almost at once, and his half-severed tongue healed.

"Let's not make this harder on each other. I didn't remove your gag so you could bite your tongue. Besides, I'm starting to run out of the potions I brought…"

Crunch. Splurt.

The moment I said I was running out, Huginn bit his tongue again. I sighed.

"I told you not to do that."

Then I rummaged through my Inventory and took out a potion.

Or rather, a box packed full of them.

Thud.

"Please. I'm asking nicely. I've only got about three hundred left. Okay?"

"…!"

"At least this time you only cut off a little bit of your tongue."

"…"

"Open your mouth. Come on. Say 'ah.'"

Huginn stared at me blankly instead of answering, so I slapped him across the face.

Smack!

Teeth flew in every direction.

But I wasn't satisfied with stopping there.

Smack! Crunch.

His jaw joint broke, and his mouth fell open on its own.

"That's it. Good job. You listen so well. But you've got tartar buildup. When was your last cleaning?"

Blood smeared around his mouth, Huginn stammered out an answer.

"Tw-two years ago…"

"That's a while. Potions aren't a cure-all. Tartar isn't an injury, so they won't heal it. You need to brush your teeth. Or go to the dentist. What do you need to do?"

"Brush my teeth, go to the dentist…"

"What are you talking about, dumbass? Just use Clean magic. Is your head for decoration? Have you kept it around since birth so you can use it as a weapon in an emergency? Did you dream of becoming a Dullahan in elementary school?"

"Why are you even—"

“But you little shit. I’ve let you get away with enough. You fucking bastard, you keep dragging this out like you’re the last royal chef of Joseon, carefully tasting everything first. What is this, a royal banquet? You’re not leaving until you’ve used every potion in this box.”

“I’ll tell you! I’ll tell you everything—!”

“Shut up.”

I didn’t know what I was saying. Or why I was acting like this.

All I knew was that the heat that had been creeping up from my gut finally reached my head.

Grab. Wham!

I snatched up a potion bottle and swung it at the top of his head. At the dull impact and surge of pain, his tightly bound body trembled.

“W-wait!”

“This is reinforced glass, you bastard.”

Wham! Wham! Crash!

Even reinforced glass could only take about three hits.

Shards showered over the top of his head, now spurting blood. The potion inside poured down with them.

Splash.

Healing and pain at the same time. A miracle.

But before he’d finished healing, I grabbed another bottle.

Whack! Whack! Whaaack!

Crash!

When I came to my senses, I found myself pawing at an empty box.

“Is… is it over?”

“No.”

I pulled a fresh box from my Inventory.

“Hang in there. There are still two hundred left.”

“…!”

“You can do it. Let’s keep at it together. I can do this all day. I might even be fine doing it every day from now on.”

Huginn stared at me wide-eyed, then spoke in a trembling voice.

“I-I said I’d talk. Why are you…”

“Bullshit. When?”

“I’ve been saying it for ages. Over and over. The whole time…”

“What a ridiculous bastard. Do I look like an idiot to you?”

“I’m telling the truth! I really did!”

“Are you yelling at me right now? Do you—do you feel so wronged you can’t stand it?”

“N-no, that’s not what I—”

“Forget it. You hurt my feelings. I’ve already got this box out, so let’s finish it before we talk again.”

“…!”

I thought I might have vaguely heard him say something like that, but what did it matter?

Thanks to Huginn’s excellent teamwork, we emptied the second box of potions, too. When I took out a third, I heard his tearful voice.

“Stop! Stooop!”

The mouth even veteran torturers hadn’t been able to pry open was now running free.

Maybe the genuine madness I’d shown had moved him, I thought. I closed the box I’d opened halfway.

“You finally understand how sincere I am.”

“…The promise you made earlier?”

“I’ll keep it. If you want to die that badly.”

“How can I trust you?”

“That’s up to you. But I swear on everything I have. That’s all.”

“…”

“So? Your answer?”

Huginn swallowed, then finally spoke.

“He did.”

“Be precise. Again.”

“The one who killed Siegfried Bassmann… was the person they call The Prophet.”

There was no doubt. Huginn was telling the truth.

But just as my suspicion became certainty, another question came to mind.

“The person they call The Prophet?”

“…Ah.”

Maybe it was because his mind was foggy. He looked like he’d said something he didn’t need to, but it was too late to take back words once he’d let them out.

There’s more.

I’d thought Michael Silbert and The Prophet were connected, but I hadn’t been able to pin down exactly how.

I glared at him, my eyes sinking deep, and spoke.

“Tell me what you mean. Tell me everything you know about The Prophet.”

“T-that…”

It was ironic.

He had to struggle not to live, but to die. Yet Huginn had been driven to the edge of a cliff. He had no choices left.

“He’s Muninn.”

“What?”

The moment I blurted out the question, a memory flashed through my mind: the day Huginn first came to Ares Guild.

Two ravens engraved into a corner of his business card.

And… the conversation I’d had with Team Leader Choi.

“Huginn and Muninn. Those two ravens are symbols of a certain god from Norse mythology.”

“Who?”

“Odin.”

“…!”

I blinked.

Odin, the supreme god. And the two ravens who served him: Huginn and Muninn.

There had never been just one crow to begin with.

Chapter 795

SYSTEM

Quest success conditions met!
Mission: Discover the truth behind the death (Complete)
Quest *An Unknown Death* successfully completed!
You have obtained the special Item *Truthful Eye*!
You have gained a large amount of EXP!

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The System messages appearing before my eyes and ringing in my ears were the final confirmation that everything Huginn had said was true.

But a Quest was just a Quest. I wanted more.

Everything about Muninn—or the person called The Prophet.

“Spill everything you know about him. Don’t leave out a single thing.”

I leaned in until Huginn’s trembling breath brushed my face.

“This isn’t what we agreed at the start…”

“An agreement? Of course I’ll keep it. Just not now.”

The condition for keeping my promise in the first place was confirming that The Prophet had killed Siegfried Bassmann. But in this relationship, I was the one holding all the cards.

“Talk. Or you’ll rot in prison until the day you die.”

“…!”

“You know what I’m like. If I say I’ll do something, I do it. Quit trying to outthink me and open your mouth. Go ahead and mix in a lie if you think you can get away with it.”

You could learn a lot from a person’s eyes. The resignation that had just taken over Huginn’s told me he’d finally given up.

“…Fuck.”

The curse came out almost like a sigh. Then he began to speak.

“I don’t know much about him, either. Not exactly what the current Muninn is like.”

I’d grabbed a potion bottle at his first words, but what he hurriedly added made me frown.

The current Muninn?

That was too loaded a phrase to brush off.

It sounded as if…

“Like he hasn’t always been the same person.”

"That's right. He's changed several times."

My mind raced. I slowly set down the potion bottle and stared at Huginn.

"Tell me more."

"Since I became an adult and officially began serving the Guild Master, I've met three Muninns. Including the ones before then, the person now called The Prophet is the fifth Muninn."

"Before that?"

"Before the Great Cataclysm ended. There were war orphans everywhere you went. I was one of them, though I wasn't a little kid."

I didn't need the details to picture what had happened.

Good people and bad people saw the world differently. Good people might have pitied the countless orphans left by the Great Cataclysm. Others saw a way to further their ambitions.

Lee Jungryong found Go Jun the same way.

The good fortune of Awakening came equally to everyone in humanity after their twentieth birthday.

In that sense, orphans with no one to rely on were lottery tickets that hadn't been scratched yet. Huginn must have been a diamond Michael Silbert had plucked from the mud.

And…

"That's when you met Muninn."

"More precisely, the first Muninn. That was the first and last time I saw him."

"The last? What happened after that?"

"The Great Cataclysm ended. The Guild Master wanted to keep my existence secret, so after I'd trained in secret for a while, he brought me to his side. That was the day I became Huginn. He introduced me to a man I'd never seen before."

"The new Muninn?"

Huginn nodded.

"What happened to the first Muninn?"

"I don't know. The Guild Master only told me he'd gone missing during the Great Cataclysm. He probably died in the war."

"Gone missing? If he was Michael Silbert's right-hand man, he must have been highly skilled."

Huginn gave a bitter smile at my look.

"If you don't believe me, I can't help that. But it's all I know. I hadn't even Awakened back then. I wasn't Huginn yet."

"When exactly was this?"

"Spring of 2021. The Guild Master was already famous. After the Great Battle of Paris, he was becoming one of the heroes who represented France—no, Europe."

I studied Huginn's expression for a moment, but couldn't find any sign of a lie in his face or eyes.

The important part came next.

"The Prophet… Who's the fifth Muninn?"

"Hmm."

"Think back. Just tell me what you know. Everything you saw and heard."

Huginn frowned in thought, but it didn't take him long to answer.

"A white man. Most of his face was covered, so I didn't get a good look at him. His build didn't seem suited to close combat, though. That was only my impression."

You couldn't judge a Hunter by their build alone—not when you had someone like Jeok Cheongang, with his slight frame, as proof.

But if someone as skilled as Huginn had gotten that impression, it was worth taking seriously.

The problem was that it gave me nowhere near enough to identify The Prophet.

"A white man. Possibly a ranged Hunter. That's all you know?"

Huginn swallowed dryly at my calm but icy voice, then answered.

"That's why I said I didn't know much. I saw him only once, about three years ago. And even then, the Guild Master ordered me to leave right away."

"Then how do you know he's The Prophet? Or that he killed Siegfried Bassmann?"

"The Guild Master told me when the time came. That's how it's always worked with Muninn."

"Always?"

"I stayed by the Guild Master's side and acted as his hands and feet. They were weapons he sent on more dangerous missions. They'd be gone for a year, sometimes several years, then suddenly appear again. I was always brought in afterward."

"For example?"

"Information about Sky—Cheon Taemin. And…"

"And what?"

"That…"

Smack!

My palm whipped across Huginn's cheek. He spat blood and muttered a few words through his pained expression.

"Tokyo. Leviathan. A Magic Gem."

"…!"

"The Muninn from three years ago brought back all that information. That's everything. Damn it."

I stared at Huginn, frozen like a statue.

Anger?

No. Shock.

He knew about Leviathan from the start. He used a Magic Gem to lure it to Tokyo.

And the one who gave that information to Michael Silbert was none other than Muninn—the very man now called The Prophet.

The truth sent a chill down my spine, as if someone had poured ice water over me.

How the hell?

For all the heights modern civilization had reached, the deep sea remained largely unexplored. Yet he'd learned of the calamity lurking in its dark depths.

Perhaps he'd done it all on Michael Silbert's orders. But was that the whole story?

Damn it.

I swallowed the curse rising in my chest.

Now I understood why no one had ever noticed Muninn.

A hidden blade who visited Michael Silbert in secret, sometimes after a year, more often after several. Unlike Huginn, he hadn't stayed at Silbert's side day to day. And since he was sometimes replaced because of his dangerous missions, there'd been no way to notice him.

Even Huginn, who'd handled most of Michael Silbert's affairs as his right hand, barely knew anything about Muninn.

One thing was certain.

He's dangerous. Far more dangerous than I thought.

He'd taken down Siegfried Bassmann, an outstanding Grand Mage, all on his own. He'd also drawn the outlines of the events behind this terrorist attack and supplied the information to Michael Silbert.

Michael Silbert hadn't done it on his own.

Michael Silbert had reached his current position thanks to the loyal Muninns who'd died for him.

I didn't know what the earlier Muninns had accomplished. But the man I now knew as The Prophet was far more than a mere subordinate.

Another root. Or a second Michael Silbert.

Where the hell did he find people like them?

No matter how vast the world was, no matter how many secrets it held, things eventually leaked out somewhere. Just as the great Guilds secretly trained new S-rank Hunters beyond the public eye.

This was beyond anything I'd imagined.

They must have been handling the dirty work for a long time.

Five Muninns. And the fifth Muninn.

They were Michael Silbert's darkest shadows. For years, they'd smuggled unrefined Magic Gems out of the Middle East and Africa without pause and stored

them away. They'd been his warehouse keepers, his informants, and the blades he used to eliminate rivals.

At least until Michael Silbert died.

But now the Prophet had all of it.

He wasn't merely a pair of hands and feet like Huginn. The arm called Muninn had broken away from its dead master's body and grown a body of its own.

The Prophet.

An heir who commanded countless fanatics of a religion followed by twenty percent of the world's population, and who'd inherited everything his dead master had hidden.

That madman now held the knife by the handle.

And maybe…

"Fuck."

No. Not that. I couldn't jump to conclusions on information I wasn't even sure of, especially now.

I forced the thought from my mind and sprang to my feet.

I had to tell everyone what I'd learned and call back the search teams scattered across the Middle East, as fast as I could. The Prophet was strong enough to kill a Grand Mage alone. I'd sent those teams into the desert to prevent more deaths, not to throw their lives away.

"W-wait!"

Right. Huginn was still here.

I turned at his desperate cry. Before he could say another word, I snatched a potion bottle from the box and brought it down on the crown of his head with lightning speed.

Crash! Thud.

Huginn lost consciousness in a single blow and toppled over with his chair.

A concussion at the very least. But he'd been drenched in potion, so he'd probably be fine.

"Live a nice, long life, okay?"

I spat phlegm toward him, brushed the glass dust off my hand, and walked outside.

I nodded toward the torture technicians pacing outside the door.

"He talked a fair bit, but there might be more he hasn't told us."

"Oh, then…?"

"Get it out of him. Squeeze out every last thing, even if you have to wring his soul dry."

Their faces lit up.

"Yes, sir."

“I’ll do my best. There are a lot of methods we haven’t tried yet.”

“Oh, look at this, Michael! Santa left us a whole box of potions!”

“We’ll put them to good use, Boss!”

A promise?

You make those with people. Not trash like Huginn.

“Everyone on the leadership team, to the strategy room. Right now.”

I listened to Team Leader Choi answer over the phone as I crossed the hallway.

Then I turned to look out the window.

Tonight, the moon showing through the clouds looked unusually red.

Chapter 796

That night, someone stopped in the middle of a hurried walk to look out the window. The moon seemed redder than usual.

They weren't imagining it.

A blood moon.

The phenomenon sometimes occurred during a total lunar eclipse or when the atmosphere was unstable. With magical power levels rising day by day, not just the atmosphere but the climate itself was changing.

Whoosh.

The scattered raindrops grew heavier.

A downpour that seemed out of place in this barren land, where the annual rainfall was less than 250 millimeters,[3171] soon blanketed the whole area.

Across the endless sand and the few trees scattered through it.

And over the head of someone invisible to the naked eye.

Tap. Patter-patter.

The rain struck an unseen barrier and bounced away without touching him.

The Prophet, crossing the vast desert behind an invisible barrier, abruptly looked up at the sky.

The sky was dark and noisy. Storm clouds that had looked ominous for days were unleashing rain and thunder with furious force, as though enraged by what had happened on this land.

The Prophet paid them no mind. He studied the sky—or rather, opened his senses wide and listened to every sound around him.

Rumble. Rrrumble.

Thunder boomed ceaselessly overhead. The Prophet paused to focus on the sounds around him, then muttered,

"They're gone."

The sharp cries of eagles that had echoed in the distance were gone.

The persistent flying beasts some pursuer must have sent after him had finally given up and turned back.

They were a nuisance. Good riddance.

Avoiding satellite surveillance and unmanned reconnaissance aircraft was easy enough. Magical power mixed into the atmosphere shielded him from tracking, and concealment spells weren't meant for making stew.

But those eagles were different. Even the Familiars kept by the few mages who specialized in mental magic were dirt under their claws by comparison.

[3171] 250 millimeters is about 9.8 in.

They'd followed him for hundreds of kilometers[3172] without slowing down. And their eyes shone so brightly with magical power that he'd almost thought they could see through his spells.

They can't be Familiars… It must be him.

The Skeleton King. Or the Stone King.

The Prophet frowned without realizing it. A mere monster, siding with humans.

The desert was still vast, but the undead army under that creature's command would cover more ground and cut the search time drastically.

I didn't expect this.

Then again, more than one thing had defied his expectations. He hadn't thought Michael Silbert would fall so easily, or that the World Hunter Federation would bring its chaotic ranks under control so quickly and close in on him.

But The Prophet knew what all those surprises had in common. One man.

Jin Taekyung.

Others had shone brightly before, but they'd all been meteors: a brief flash, then gone in the blink of an eye.

Jin Taekyung was different. He was a comet.

From the moment he appeared, he'd been part of the celestial body that was the world. Now he'd become its center.

He was growing so quickly that no one could predict his limits. So quickly that all The Prophet's preparations threatened to come to nothing.

Clink.

His fingers strayed to something, drawing out a faint metallic sound.

Forcing down the impatience welling up inside him, The Prophet murmured,

"Just a little more. Just a little more, and it'll be complete."

Time was the problem.

He still hadn't gathered everything needed for a plan that could not tolerate the slightest error, and his enemies' net was tightening fast.

That left The Prophet only one option.

Hunt.

But time was short. To complete his plan successfully, he had to make it bigger and bolder than before.

For example…

Vroom.

From atop a high sand dune, he spotted transport vehicles moving through a thick cloud of dust. His eyes lit up.

[3172] 100 kilometers is about 62 mi; the distance here is not specified more precisely than "hundreds."

“Chikushō.”[3173]

At Yamamoto Genji’s low curse, the Self-Defense Forces Hunters edged away from Japan’s S-rank Hunter and exchanged glances.

Japan was hardly a Hunter powerhouse, but every Hunter it had dispatched to the Middle East was a veteran among veterans. They’d known one another for years, too. By now, a glance was enough.

What’s his problem?

Isn’t it obvious? Who else could it be?

Eeh? Jin-sama?[3174]

Yeah. That transmission from headquarters really set Yamamoto-san[3175] *off.*

The story was simple. About thirty minutes earlier, headquarters had ordered an emergency withdrawal. Yamamoto Genji had refused.

A reply had come at once—not in the communications officer’s stiff voice, but in a young man’s unmistakable one.

> “When Leviathan was wrecking Tokyo Bay, you didn’t come even when we called, you son of a bitch. What? You’re not coming now? Give me your coordinates. If you won’t come to me, I’ll come to you.”

Who was Jin Taekyung?

The only person who could fill the void left by the unconscious Cheon Taemin. The Alliance Leader of the World Hunter Federation, with the support of all humanity.

But people shouldn’t forget his temper, either. Sometimes—no, fairly often—he acted without a thought for the consequences. And he had the strength to back it up.

The Self-Defense Forces Hunters, their knees weak at the Supreme One’s reply—practically a murder threat—had desperately tried to talk Yamamoto down. Even after climbing into an evacuation vehicle, Yamamoto Genji still couldn’t contain his anger.

“Konoyarō.[3176] How dare a Chōsenjin[3177]…!”

The others pretended not to hear. At a time like this, they needed to be blind and deaf.

[3173] *Chikushō* is a Japanese exclamation roughly equivalent to “damn it.”

[3174] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

[3175] *-san* is a common Japanese honorific used in polite address.

[3176] *Konoyarō* is a Japanese insult roughly equivalent to “you bastard.”

[3177] *Chōsenjin* means “Korean” in Japanese; in this context it is used as an ethnic slur.

They didn't much like Yamamoto's attitude themselves. But if word reached their superiors, they'd get cursed out—and Japan would get dragged into it with them.

More bad press?

No. Absolutely not.

The Defense Minister, who had played a major role in the Leviathan incident—including preparing a kamikaze[3178] operation—was now in a federal prison after his connection to Michael Silbert had come to light. And the kind but stupid Prime Minister couldn't even go a few days without spewing more shit.

> [Japanese Prime Minister Koizumi: "People of Yamato, fight for Jin-sama,[3179] the great shogun[3180] who defeated Susanoo for us!"]
>
> [Asked about the strategy for the Self-Defense Forces' upcoming deployment to the Middle East, Prime Minister Koizumi said, "Combat should be fun, cool, and sexy."]
>
> [Former U.S. President Joseph Biden: "I understand the Japanese Prime Minister. In the early stages of my dementia, I didn't know what I was saying, either."]
>
> [Chuck Hagel: "I think they're both just crazy."]

The Self-Defense Forces Hunters felt sorry for themselves.

The Defense Minister was set to spend his twilight years in federal prison, while the Prime Minister was using the media as a loudspeaker to announce, without a hint of restraint, that Japan's leader was a lunatic.

Even Korean netizens, who'd been holding back because of the tense mood, had started saying things like this:

> ㄴ **Top comment:** I don't really want to bring this up when things are already tense, but… do those guys have something against Japan?
>
> ㄴ The Japanese Prime Minister and Defense Minister are anti-Japan, lmao. Fuck.
>
> ㄴ If you ask me, they must've had something going on in a past life.
>
> ㄴ One of them was a turtle ship in a past life, and the other was a lunchbox bomb. Seriously, it's not easy to spew that much shit.[3181]

[3178] *Kamikaze* refers to Japanese suicide attacks, particularly those carried out by pilots during World War II.

[3179] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

[3180] A *shogun* was a military ruler of Japan.

[3181] Turtle ships were Korean warships associated with Admiral Yi Sun-sin. The lunchbox bomb refers to one Korean independence activist Yun Bong-gil used against Japanese officials in 1932.

> ㄴ I wonder if this is how the independence fighters felt when they saw Mutaguchi Renya…[3182]
>
> ㄴ Shadow independence army. Agreed.
>
> ㄴ Sushi country: “Uh, what are those guys doing?”

And now Yamamoto Genji, once called the pride of the island nation, had lost face too. People had learned that he’d failed to show up twice in a row: first during the Leviathan incident, then at the launch ceremony.

Why had he skipped the launch ceremony?

The Self-Defense Forces Hunters didn’t know. If they’d known the real reason, they’d have spat in his face, pride of the island nation or not.

Yamamoto Genji had simply been… embarrassed.

Damn it. I should’ve gone.

He’d avoided Leviathan because he was afraid. Then he’d made up a personal excuse to skip the launch ceremony because he didn’t want to face Jin Taekyung.

That might have kept him alive and in one piece. But once it was all over, something worse than death had been waiting for him.

> ㄴ Those guys really are something. That S-rank Hunter hasn’t shown his face once, even now, lmao. What was his name again?
>
> ㄴ Genji.
>
> ㄴ Isn’t it Hanzo?
>
> ㄴ That’s Genji’s older brother.
>
> ㄴ Are you guys insane?
>
> ㄴ Why are you talking about a dead game from ages ago, you fossils?
>
> ㄴ It’s true, though? Look it up if you don’t believe me.
>
> ㄴ ?
>
> ㄴ It’s real; he actually has an older brother named Yamamoto Hanzo.
>
> ㄴ How is this real?
>
> ㄴ So can Genji use Swift Strike?[3183]
>
> ㄴ He’s great at Swift No-Show.
>
> ㄴ LMAO
>
> ㄴ Goddamn, that really hurts my pride.

[3182] Mutaguchi Renya was a Japanese general associated with the disastrous Imphal campaign of World War II.

[3183] Swift Strike is the English name of an ability in the video game *Overwatch*.

[3184] In Japanese online writing, repeated *w* represents laughter.

> ㄴ wwwwwww[3184] I was about to get mad, but I laughed without even realizing it?
>
> ㄴ “Don’t laugh at him too much, okay? I thought it was kind of funny, though.” wwwww
>
> ㄴ Even wasabi’s laughing, lmao.
>
> ㄴ Lmao, wasabi showed up, but where’s the black bean sauce?
>
> ㄴ It’s now confirmed that Jin Taekyung is from Shanxi Province, China. After examining old historical records, renowned historians at Peking University discovered the Jin Family of Taiyuan (see more)
>
> ㄴ ;;;; The second they see an opening, these bastards launch straight into their Jin-is-Chinese campaign.[3185]
>
> ㄴ Didn’t the Red Guards destroy their old records?
>
> ㄴ (This comment has been hidden.)
>
> ㄴ So did Genji—or was it Hanzo—actually go to the Middle East this time?
>
> ㄴ Yeah. I heard they accepted him since he’s an S-rank Hunter, at least.
>
> ㄴ Isn’t he just going to sit out the fighting? Doesn’t seem like he’d be much help anyway. They should just send him around to entertain the troops.
>
> ㄴ Captain Wasabi.

How dare they? How dare they insult me—Genji—like that?

Remembering the comments, Yamamoto shuddered.

Swift No-Show. Captain Wasabi.

The more he turned those words over, like awls digging into his lungs, the more his rage made him tremble.

And on top of that…

That rude reply? In front of the Self-Defense Forces?

Jin Taekyung’s warning, which was practically a threat—and the way the Self-Defense Forces Hunters had hurried to hold Yamamoto back instead of getting angry at such rudeness—had stripped away every last bit of Yamamoto Genji’s pride.

If I go back now, what does that make me?

By all accounts, he was an S-rank Hunter. But everyone who’d heard the rumors looked down on him. He’d scoured the desert with everything he had, determined to change how they saw him, and it had looked as if he was about to get results.

And now, an emergency withdrawal order.

Yamamoto had been muttering curses under his breath nonstop when a suspicion struck him.

[3185] The comment alludes to the *Northeast Project*, a Chinese historical research project criticized in Korea for claiming parts of Korean history as Chinese.

That Chōsenjin… Could it be? No. Of course it is.

That was it. All of this was Jin Taekyung's scheme to stop him from earning credit. The anti-Japanese sentiment that had started long ago had followed him all the way here.

Having reached a conclusion that was practically a delusion, Yamamoto barked,

"Oi, sutoppu!"

At his sudden order to stop, the evacuation vehicle ground to a halt.

Unlike before they'd set out, when they'd strongly objected to disobeying the withdrawal order, the Self-Defense Forces Hunters now meekly followed his command. Yamamoto's face brightened.

That's right. I'm the beacon of the great Yamato people! The one they follow isn't that Korean—it's me…!

The thought broke off.

The Self-Defense Forces Hunters looked bewildered. At the same instant, a realization flashed through Yamamoto's mind.

"Wait. Who's in the driver's seat?"

One of the Self-Defense Forces Hunters blinked and answered,

"No one."

"Eeh?"

"It's an unmanned vehicle."

Silence fell.

They stared at one another, then understood why the vehicle had stopped when it had been driving along just fine.

And why they could no longer hear the rain that had been pouring all around them.

"Ambu—!"

"Ambush!"

And at the same time—

BOOM!

A tremendous roar and impact engulfed them.

Chapter 797

In just a few days, the main force had built a solid command structure and amassed tremendous fighting strength.

The World Hunter Federation had led the way. The major powers of the G20 were among the first to lend their strength, and even the UN peacekeeping forces, forged into elite troops by the Great Cataclysm, had joined them.

The people gathered in the strategy room were the head and limbs that moved this enormous body.

"So…"

Chuck Hagel had listened to my explanation in silence. Now he spoke slowly.

"That fucking terrorist has been covering Michael Silbert's ass from the very beginning?"

I nodded without hesitation.

"Yes."

"You believe him? Huginn, I mean."

"Am I crazy? I wouldn't trust a bastard like that."

"Then what do you believe?"

"His fear."

Chuck Hagel studied me for a moment, then tapped the ash from his cigar.

"Sounds like it's true."

"At least, that's how it felt to me."

"You're sure?"

"Not a hundred percent. Maybe ninety-five. Even Huginn has no reason to lie in a situation like this."

"What about the other five percent?"

"The people visiting him with knives in hand are filling that in. Maybe we're up to ninety-seven by now."

The first confession was the hard part. After that, it got easier. Now that Huginn had started talking, he'd drag out everything he knew—even things he'd forgotten.

Pain wasn't what broke a strong person. It was the fear inside them.

Of course, he'll be tortured plenty before then.

Everyone here probably knew what was happening, but no one said it aloud.

What mattered now wasn't Huginn, who was probably being reduced to a bloody mess. It was what we did next.

We had to make a new plan on the assumption that everything he'd confessed was true. The Prophet wasn't just some lunatic terrorist. He was strong enough to kill a Grand Mage on his own.

"How strong do you think he is?" Team Leader Choi asked cautiously.

Chuck Hagel smacked his lips. "Hard to say. We know next to nothing about him."

"Mr. Hagel, this may be an impolite question, but if you'd been in The Prophet's position and targeted Siegfried Bassmann, how would you have fared?"

"I'd met Siegfried. We weren't close, but I could've taken him out easily. For someone he didn't know, though? Given how reclusive he was, it would've been close to impossible."

"Then could it be…"

"It's one of two things. Either The Prophet was so strong that Siegfried couldn't even defend himself properly, or…" Chuck Hagel paused. "He was someone Siegfried had met before."

"…!"

"…!"

The strategy room went cold.

The weight of what Chuck Hagel had said stunned everyone. We didn't know which possibility applied to The Prophet. Either way, we were dealing with someone far stronger than we'd expected.

"Jin was right to call the search teams back," Hagel said. "If they stayed scattered, they'd be easy to pick off one by one. Of course, if The Prophet is that strong, gathering a few hundred people might not help."

He was right. Even among S-rank Hunters—practically strategic weapons in their own right—there were clear differences in strength.

It was unlikely, but if The Prophet was comparable to Michael Silbert, it would take three average S-rank Hunters attacking together, backed by a supporting force, to bring him down.

The problem is, where the hell did someone that strong come from?

No matter how I looked at it, I couldn't figure it out.

The World Hunter Federation had already cleaned house and accounted for the whereabouts and circumstances of every living S-rank Hunter and every other major Hunter.

He's not an insider. So what is he?

An unknown outsider. And from what Huginn had told me, an outsider who'd appeared no more than five years ago.

Huginn had first seen The Prophet three years ago, but he'd last seen the fourth Muninn five years ago.

Siegfried Bassmann, meanwhile, was a veteran among veterans who'd fought countless battles during the Great Cataclysm. He might have been a scholarly mage, but no one earned the title of Grand Mage through books and research alone.

However talented The Prophet was, there should have been an unbridgeable gap between them. Some kid who'd dropped out of the sky a few years ago couldn't overcome a gap like that.

Except…

I was living proof that it could be done.

"The System…?"

"Hm?"

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

Chuck Hagel raised an eyebrow. I acted like nothing had happened and changed the subject.

"Anyway, how's the withdrawal going?"

Team Leader Choi answered. "More than seventy percent of the search personnel have returned."

"Faster than I expected."

"We mobilized every means of transport we have. We've also informed Magic Johnson, Faye Chen, and Prince Felix of the situation and made the withdrawal of all search teams their top priority."

This was the operations headquarters, but the others each commanded a force of their own according to their abilities. We'd had to spread out to search this vast region thoroughly. Making every team travel thousands—sometimes tens of thousands—of kilometers[3186] back here whenever it needed to return would have been stupid.

"All of Team A1 has returned."

"Team B2 is still on its way back. We expect them within fifteen minutes and remain in contact."

"We've temporarily lost contact with Team D4. We suspect interference from magical power and have dispatched a support team as a precaution."

Reports poured in from all around the room, starting with Team Leader Choi.

Some search teams under headquarters command hadn't returned yet, and others were out of contact. For now, though, there was no reason to worry. As magical power levels rose, mana communications and radio signals naturally grew less reliable.

And even if something like a Monster Wave happened, *that guy* could handle it.

Beep.

—Emergency transmission, emergency transmission. This is Team F6. A monster army has appeared ahead. The monsters appear to be undead. Requesting support.

"…"

[3186] 1,000 kilometers is about 620 mi; 10,000 kilometers is about 6,200 mi.

"…"

Team Leader Choi and I met eyes and sighed at the same time.

"Tell them not to attack."

"Uh, they're probably on our side."

Chuck Hagel had sprung to his feet the moment the radio sounded. Now he looked as though he'd bitten into something foul.

"Damn it. Is it the guy I'm thinking of?"

"Yes. Judging by Team F6's current coordinates, it's definitely him. They must've gotten confused."

"Tell him not to scare the troops. Plenty of them haven't seen him in person. We don't need the confusion."

"The Skeleton King will take that into account, so there's no need to worry too much—"

Beep-beep!

—Emergency transmission! Emergency transmission! There are too many monsters! There's a boss, possibly a named monster, and it's laughing like a maniac! It's terrifying! Requesting support!

"…"

Chuck Hagel gave us a flat look.

Team Leader Choi glanced away and muttered as if to himself, "No one will get hurt. Probably…"

"That last word didn't sound very confident. Am I imagining things?"

"Yes."

I let out a long sigh.

I'd sent that bastard to bring the troops back, and now he was scaring them instead.

Judging by the looks on the faces of the commanders seated around us, they were wondering whether we ought to deal with the Skeleton King before The Prophet.

You're dead when you get back.

Just as I muttered to myself, another urgent transmission rang out.

Beep.

—Engagement in progress! Engagement in progress!

"Again?"

He was *really* dead.

But as I wondered how I could deal with the Skeleton King in a way that would make the story of his getting his ass kicked spread far and wide, an unexpected follow-up crackled in my ear.

—This is Team J1! Multiple dead! Multiple injured! Send support as fast as you can, aaagh!

Crunch. Splaash!

A chill ran down my spine.

The gruesome sound of flesh tearing and that scream came through the radio. Everyone in the strategy room, myself included, sprang to their feet.

“Fuck!”

“Find the transmitter’s coordinates! Now!”

“Sound the alarm! Dispatch the nearest search team to those coordinates immediately!”

“Teams P3 and P4 are moving within thirty-five kilometers[3187]!”

“Get the orders out! Hurry! And request support from the Skeleton King, too!”

Wheeeee!

The alarm blared through the speakers and spread into the darkness.

I threw myself out the open window and shot high into the air. A flash lit up the distance. I drew up my internal energy.

Bang!

The wind rushing past me seemed to carry the metallic scent of blood.

Whoosh. Boom!

Bone and flesh burst apart with a heavy rush of air.

The headless corpse dropped to its knees, and furious shouts erupted from every direction.

“No! Haruka!”

“You bastard! How dare you!”

Shing, shing, shing!

Blades swept through the darkness, cutting through sand thrown up by the force of their swings. They drove toward the enemy who had killed their precious comrade.

They thought they could cut him to pieces.

Then the sand beneath their feet surged upward, became enormous spikes, and pierced their bodies.

Thud! Crunch!

“Ghk.”

“Guh…!”

Their final gasps escaped as dark red blood soaked the sand.

Hundreds dwindled to a hundred, then a hundred to dozens, in little more than ten minutes.

[3187] Thirty-five kilometers is about 22 mi.

Those who watched it happen trembled with fear that reached their bones. S-rank Hunter Yamamoto Genji was no exception.

This… This can't be real.

People could call him Swift No-Show or an S-rank janitor, but he was still a veteran Hunter who'd fought his share of battles.

Even Yamamoto had never seen a fight this brutal or this one-sided.

Overwhelming power. Destruction. Terror.

No word he knew could describe the gulf between them.

He was too frightened to run. Too frightened even to swing the sword he'd drawn.

"What… What the hell are you?"

Slice!

An invisible wind cut down another person in place of an answer.

The tank who'd charged forward with a scream split in two, massive Tower Shield and all. Blood sprayed through the air, vivid even in the dark.

Splaash. Thud-thud!

Deep night. Dim moonlight.

A lone figure stood amid blood falling like a sudden downpour.

Rustle.

The hem of a long robe brushed the blood-soaked sand as the figure turned. Yamamoto Genji suddenly realized who had ambushed them.

"The… The Prophet…!"

Beneath the low-drawn hood, the figure's lips curved gently upward.

The Prophet thrust out both hands and raked them down through the air like claws.

Whoosh! Slice!

Had space itself warped, or had he imagined it?

Yamamoto looked around in a daze. Corpses lay everywhere: faces gone, holes punched through chests, limbs severed.

Before he knew it, he was the only one left alive.

For the moment.

I'm going to die. I know it.

The fear of death was the one thing everyone shared.

Step.

Yamamoto took a step back without realizing it. He didn't notice the sword hilt slipping from his sweat-slick hand.

No. He didn't care.

If only he could survive. If only he could make it back to Japan alive.

But the next moment, someone's unfamiliar voice pierced his ear.

“Where are you going in such a hurry, foolish servant?”
“…!”
Just as Yamamoto Genji froze like a statue—
“Over there!”
“Someone’s there!”
“Get into formation!”
Vrooom.
Transport vehicle engines and people’s shouts sounded from every direction.

Chapter 798

I knew. No matter how extraordinary your abilities were, you couldn't prevent every tragedy in the world.

But every second felt like an hour because the people falling and spilling their blood at this very moment were suffering because of me.

I was the one who'd called them to this distant desert in a foreign land. I was the one who'd led them to their deaths.

Once I took on the title of Alliance Leader, I had to bear that anguish until this war was over. I had to lead from the front and fight harder than anyone else.

Whoosh!

I shot forward, cutting through the fierce wind.

My qinggong[3188] had long since surpassed the realm of Treading Snow Without a Trace. It left no footprints even on fine sand, and each step carried me dozens of meters.[3189]

Faster. Faster. Just a little faster.

I hadn't looked back once, but I knew I'd come so far that headquarters, which had stood like a fortress in the desert, was no longer visible.

I knew, too, that I was getting closer to the faint lights I'd spotted when I'd leapt into the sky.

But why…?

Why was it so quiet?

My heart sank at the thought I couldn't bring myself to finish. I gritted my teeth and stamped down with all my strength.

Rumble.

The internal energy flowing through my toes shook the ground. For an instant, my muscles compressed like a spring, then recoiled with explosive force.

Boom!

I shot forward like a cannonball, the air booming around me. At the same time, faint sounds reached me on the wind.

—…What the hell… that bastard…

—Hans! Hans!

—Fled… survivor… contact headquarters…

Snatches of voices came through the sound of vehicle engines.

As I drew closer, I sensed plenty of people and heard plenty of noise. The casualties couldn't have been too severe.

"Ah."

[3188] *Qinggong* is a Chinese martial-arts term for skills associated with light, swift movement.

[3189] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

Only then did I let out a sigh of relief and pick up the pace.

A moment later, I saw what lay ahead and understood.

Every person I'd sensed, every voice I'd heard, belonged to those who had arrived before me.

"…!"

I froze, staring at hundreds of bodies dried out like mummies.

The people's eyes turned toward me. Their murmuring felt as distant as an echo.

Only one word filled my mind.

The Prophet.

No doubt about it.

He'd been here.

And maybe…

He's still nearby. He has to be.

Mourning the dead would have to wait. If we didn't catch him here today, the death toll could climb tens or hundreds of times higher.

Where are you?

My heart burned, but my mind was cold as ice. With my senses sharper than ever, I spread my Qi Sense.

Fwoosh.

Invisible qi swept across the sand as I launched myself forward.

Whooosh!

Beyond the sand surging up like a wave, a familiar face flashed into view.

The Skeleton King was shouting something urgently among the reinforcements, but I was already streaking across the desert like a beam of light. Every one of my senses was fixed on a single presence.

The Prophet.

Today, right here, I had to tear out the diseased tree's last root.

If everything had gone the way I wanted, I probably wouldn't be here now. My father wouldn't have died, and my mother wouldn't have gotten sick.

If things had turned out that way, I… I don't know.

My school grades were a disaster, and the only thing I had going for me was a healthy body.

Yeah, fuck.

It was a pointless wish. Bullshit that could never come true anyway.

Things had never gone the way I wanted. This time was no different.

"Hell of a morning, isn't it, Jin?"

I dropped down beside Magic Johnson, who greeted me with an exhausted face.

Neither of us asked the other how it had gone. We already knew six hours of searching had come to nothing.

Still, I spoke up, hoping against hope.

"Johnson."

"I'm sorry."

"…"

"We searched every inch of a 700-kilometer[3190] radius. We practically threatened Syria and Iraq into cooperating, too. But, damn it…"

The Prophet was gone.

No—he'd vanished.

As if he'd never existed in this world at all.

No wonder the elite Hunters who'd joined the search right after me all looked as if they'd seen a ghost.

"We were so close. Where the hell did he run off to?"

The reinforcements had moved quickly. They'd reached the scene less than fifteen minutes after J1, a team of roughly two hundred Japanese Hunters, reported an engagement.

The problem was that The Prophet had left the battlefield just before they arrived, and no one could find him anywhere.

"Jin. As far as I know, there's only one way to explain this."

Our eyes met. I murmured, "Magic."

"Right. The Prophet is a mage. One so skilled that even Grand Mage might not do him justice."

Magic Johnson's magic hadn't found a trace of him. Neither had the Skeleton King's undead army. Neither had I.

That left one possibility.

Magic.

People called things they couldn't explain miracles, or said they were like magic. In The Prophet's case, it had to be the latter.

He couldn't actually be chosen by God, whatever the fanatics brainwashed into following him believed.

A mage, huh.

Huginn's words came back to me. He'd said The Prophet seemed to be a ranged Hunter.

I'd had my doubts, but now the evidence was tipping that way.

[3190] 700 km is about 435 mi.

The Prophet was probably a mage—and one skilled enough to vanish without Magic Johnson detecting him.

Or…

One of his subordinates could be a mage at that level.

If that was true, it'd be the worst of the worst. Fortunately, Magic Johnson immediately shook his head when he heard my thought.

"That's not it."

"I hope you're right, but there's still a chance…"

"The Prophet was definitely alone."

"What?"

That wasn't a guess. I could hear the certainty in his voice, and his next words told me why.

"There's a survivor, Jin."

"…!"

"The only survivor from J1. He woke up not long before you arrived."

The only survivor.

I couldn't just sit there and listen after hearing those words. I sprang to my feet and asked Magic Johnson,

"Where is he now?"

The survivor lay in bed, hooked up to all kinds of medical equipment.

Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King had been talking beside the bed with serious expressions. They opened their mouths as if to say something when they saw me, but then closed them again.

My face must have told them the search that had lasted until dawn had failed.

"That him?"

The Skeleton King understood immediately and nodded.

"Yeah. The only human who survived there."

"Then when I first got to the scene…"

"By then, every last one of them was dead. Not a single wounded person left. That human was in critical condition, too, but he got lucky. You came in, didn't even listen properly, and left again right away."

Only then did I remember the frantic moments when I'd reached the scene: the word *survivor* amid the voices I'd heard on my way there, and the Skeleton King trying to tell me something as I left.

"You left before I could say a word. I was about to go after you, but I stopped myself. Something else could've happened with me away from here, too."

The Skeleton King had made the right call. Maybe he'd read the situation more calmly than I had.

Seeing me bite my lip in silence, Team Leader Choi spoke.

"You both made the right decisions. What matters now is that we have a survivor."

More than a hundred people had died. That was tragic, but the fact that someone had survived was a stroke of luck—for the man who'd lived through that horrific scene, and for all of us.

"He woke up a little while ago, six hours after we found him. The healer in charge says he's had enough potions and is in the final stage of recovery. He should be fine."

I studied the survivor. He was staring into space with his mouth hanging open.

He didn't look fine, for one thing. For another, his face seemed familiar. And even without checking his pulse, I could sense the abundant energy inside him.

Wait. Could this guy be…?

I turned toward Team Leader Choi. He nodded as if he'd read my mind, and a quiet Sound Transmission reached my ears alone.

—He's the person you're thinking of, Mr. Jin Taekyung. Japan's S-rank Hunter, Yamamoto Genji, is J1's only survivor.

—…!

—It was a close call. From what we can piece together, reinforcements were about to arrive. The Prophet must have worried they'd hold him up, so he left before he could finish Yamamoto off.

The five hundred Hunters who'd responded as reinforcements had been lucky.

If The Prophet had been a little stupider, or more confident in his own strength, they wouldn't have escaped death either.

But he was clever and cautious. He knew that the longer he stayed in one place, the greater the threat he would face.

That was bad news for humanity, but good luck for those who'd survived.

By that measure, the man before me—Yamamoto Genji, still staring into space with unfocused eyes—had been extraordinarily lucky.

Of course, having gone through something similar myself, I didn't think of it that way.

Damn it.

I hated Yamamoto Genji. More than hated him. What I felt was closer to loathing.

When so many people had risked their lives to stop Leviathan, he'd shown up late with a ridiculous excuse.

The only reason I'd gone out of my way to bring someone like him into the World Hunter Federation was that he was an S-rank Hunter. I'd figured that even a useless bastard might pull his weight at least once.

But whatever I thought of him, I had no right to curse Yamamoto Genji now.

I wasn't going to ask why he alone had come back alive when everyone else was dead.

I was the one who'd sent him—and all of them—into that deathtrap.

Tap.

I took Yamamoto Genji's wrist and sent my internal energy into him.

My Scorching Yang Qi, warm to the touch, flowed through his pulse and into his body. His erratic heartbeat steadied, and a flush of warmth spread across his pale face.

"Yamamoto."

I said his name quietly. His parched lips moved.

"…A-ah."

I kept sending internal energy into him as I watched his mouth open and close, as if he'd forgotten how to speak.

I don't know how long we stayed like that. At last, his eyes came into focus. Yamamoto Genji looked at me and spoke.

"Cho…"

"Cho?"

"Chōsenjin?"[3191]

Wait, this fucking bastard.

[3191] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

Chapter 799

If the N-word is the button that sets Black people off, then *Chōsenjin*[3192] is the Korean-only special edition.

It's bad enough when Korean weebs who've overdosed on Japanophilia start throwing around *Chōsenjin*[3193]. But you hear its full ugliness when it comes straight from a Japanese guy.

Like right now.

"Chōsenjin?"[3194]

The moment that magic word reached my ears, the will of Hongik Ingan, passed down from Grandfather Dangun in the distant past, and the vital essence of Joseon's eight provinces surged up from deep within me.[3195]

And if you compressed that long-winded sentence into four syllables, you'd get something completely unrelated: Scorching Yang Qi.

Honestly, I was pissed off and just spouting whatever came to mind.

Whoosh!

"Uh. Uh-oh…"

"Please don't, Mr. Jin!"

The sudden burst of heat made the Skeleton King swallow saliva he didn't even have. Team Leader Choi launched himself at me like a football player and grabbed hold.

"You can't hit him yet! He's a patient!"

"Right. Team Leader Choi is right."

"Yes, yes. So…"

"But so what?"

"Huh?"

"Let go. That bastard's pissing me off."

I pried Team Leader Choi's arms from around my waist and muttered, "Ahn Jung-geun. Yun Bong-gil. Yu Gwan-sun. Ahn Chang-ho. Kim Won-bong…"[3196]

"Gasp."

"Mutaguchi Renya.[3197] Little Boy. Fat Man…"[3198]

[3192] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

[3193] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

[3194] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

[3195] Hongik Ingan, "to broadly benefit humanity," is the founding ideal attributed to Dangun, Korea's legendary first king. "Joseon's eight provinces" is a traditional expression for the whole country.

[3196] The five people named here are figures in the Korean independence movement against Japanese colonial rule.

[3197] Mutaguchi Renya was a Japanese general in World War II, associated with the disastrous Imphal campaign.

[3198] Little Boy and Fat Man were the atomic bombs dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, respectively, in 1945.

"Help! I can't hold him back by myself!"

At Team Leader Choi's cry for backup, the Skeleton King answered calmly.

"Even the two of us couldn't stop him."

"We need to hear his testimony!"

"We do. But who's going to take responsibility for my beautiful skull if it gets smashed trying to stop him?"

"Johnson! Mr. Johnson! Help!"

Bang!

"Who dares bully my Choi—Oh."

Magic Johnson burst through the door like a knight in shining armor, then blinked.

"What on earth is going on?"

"Hmm. A wicked human is trying to kill a monkey human."

"What the fuck? Why?"

"Because the monkey human called the wicked human *Chōsenjin*."[3199]

"Chōsenjin?"[3200]

Magic Johnson still looked puzzled. The Skeleton King helpfully explained.

"As far as I know, it means about the same thing as 'nigger.'"

"Motherfucking Japs! You goddamn son of a beach! Jin! Kill that bastard right now!"

Even the hulking Grand Mage, well over two meters tall,[3201] had started raging. Team Leader Choi muttered so quietly I could barely hear him.

"Fuck, I really can't do this anymore…"

"Oh."

When I'd first met him, I'd thought, *What kind of Young Master is this?* But now, even the occasional swear that slipped out of him sounded native.

Was this how a master felt when he saw his Disciple grow?

I looked at Team Leader Choi with pride.

"You've come a long way."

"Quit screwing around and finish what you were doing."

"I'm really going to hit him, you know?"

"You were going to do it even if I stopped you, so why ask? Just one hit. And go easy."

"Okay."

With that settled, I turned around. Yamamoto Genji had become the picture of politeness.

[3199] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

[3200] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

[3201] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

"I'm sorry. I was out of my mind earlier."

"Yeah. I'm sorry in advance, too."

"Mr. Jin…"

"No, just call me *Chōsenjin*.[3202] That'll make me feel better."

"Jin-sama!"[3203]

After a three-stage transformation in how he addressed me that would've put Frieza[3204] to shame, Yamamoto Genji sprang to his feet, dropped to his knees, and pressed his forehead to the floor.

"I sincerely apologize!"

"…Did you go to a dogeza[3205] academy or something?"

It was a perfect, textbook dogeza.[3206]

At this point, I was starting to wonder whether dogeza[3207] was part of the Japanese S-rank Hunter certification test.

I sighed and shook my head, then stared silently at the back of Yamamoto Genji's head.

Damn it.

Whatever else, he'd come all the way to the Middle East on my orders.

He'd hesitated for a while even after the order to withdraw, and in the end he'd lost every member of his team. But if you looked at it closely, I was more or less responsible for all of it as the one in command.

If Yamamoto Genji was an incompetent defeated general, then I was a pathetic commander who'd entrusted hundreds of lives to a man like that.

"Get up."

"…"

"I said, get up."

"H-hai."

Yamamoto Genji cautiously sat back on his heels.

His potion shower had left his body without a scratch. And judging by his wide-open eyes, his mind seemed to be working properly again, too.

"Tell me everything that happened. From beginning to end. Don't leave anything out."

Yamamoto Genji hesitated, licked his parched lips, and finally began.

[3202] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans, used here as an ethnic slur.

[3203] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific conveying a higher degree of deference than *-san*.

[3204] Frieza is a *Dragon Ball* character known for transforming through multiple forms.

[3205] *Dogeza* is a formal Japanese gesture of apology or supplication performed while kneeling and bowing to the floor.

[3206] *Dogeza* is a formal Japanese gesture of apology or supplication performed while kneeling and bowing to the floor.

[3207] *Dogeza* is a formal Japanese gesture of apology or supplication performed while kneeling and bowing to the floor.

“We were traveling in unmanned transport vehicles when he appeared.”

“The Prophet?”

“…Yes.”

At the mention of The Prophet, Yamamoto Genji shuddered and swallowed.

“The vehicles suddenly stopped, and an unfamiliar energy sent a chill through my whole body.”

He was a coward and a fool, but he was still an S-rank Hunter. He must’ve instinctively sensed that something was wrong.

But…

“The vehicles stopped? On their own?”

“Y-yes.”

Magic Johnson met my gaze and spoke.

“It was magic. He must have used mana interference to shut down the Magic Gems powering the unmanned transport vehicles.”

“What are the odds it was an artifact?”

“That’s possible. But I understand J1 had ten vehicles assigned to them. Is that right?”

Yamamoto Genji answered.

“That’s right. They all stopped at once.”

“Magic used through an artifact has clear limitations. He’s definitely a mage.”

“R-right. That’s right.”

Yamamoto Genji nodded spasmodically, like someone being chased, and continued.

“I saw it clearly. The flash of light, the blood, people falling at a single gesture… I’d never seen anything like it. Everyone around me died in the blink of an eye. It was definitely magic.”

As if he were reliving the terror of that moment, his hands and feet began to tremble.

I watched him for a while, then asked, “What about you?”

“Huh?”

“How did you survive?”

“Th-that…”

His pupils, which had just managed to refocus, wavered.

He reflexively avoided my gaze. I saw no grief over the loss of his comrades, no anger at himself.

Fear.

The only things Yamamoto Genji felt now were fear of The Prophet and relief at having survived.

"You ran. No—did you try to run and fail?"

"…!"

You son of a bitch.

He flinched as if I'd hit the mark, and something hot surged up inside me.

If someone hadn't grabbed my shoulder, I would've punched that cowardly face of his, testimony or no testimony.

Damn it.

I chewed on my lip, trying to hold down the bitterness and anger.

I silently glared at Yamamoto Genji, his head bowed. A long time passed before I spoke again.

"What happened after that?"

Yamamoto Genji kept his head down, his eyes darting around, and answered cautiously.

"He heard the reinforcements arriving and left."

"Was the situation so urgent that he had to leave you behind, an S-rank Hunter? The Prophet must have known you'd be a problem if he let you live."

"Th-that…"

Yamamoto Genji hesitated at Team Leader Choi's sharp question, then answered.

"He must have had another reason."

"Another reason…?"

"He sucked everything out of my teammates who'd died before me."

"What?"

Sucked everything out of them?

The rest of us stared at him, unable to make sense of his words. Yamamoto Genji hurriedly continued.

"I-I swear I'm not lying. He sucked up the pools of blood all around us, too. He pulled something like a pale mist out of the dead people's bodies and swallowed it. After that, the corpses dried up like mummies…"

It was like being struck in the back of the head. The words that followed came through only faintly.

And I wasn't the only one stunned.

"No. This… That isn't magic."

Magic Johnson muttered as if he were groaning and rubbed his forehead. Under the lights, his forehead had grown damp with cold sweat.

"Damn it. What the hell is it? As far as I know, there's no magic available to humans that could do something that horrifying…"

His voice trembled. He fell silent, stood frozen like a statue, then slowly turned his head.

No—all of us did.

And there, at the end of our gazes, stood one being.

The Skeleton King.

My friend. A comrade I could trust with my back.

But we'd instinctively looked at him because the answer to The Prophet lay in his very existence.

Someone who used magic unavailable to humans.

A powerful being capable of taking out a Grand Mage single-handedly, whose strength had never once been revealed to the world.

Another secret Michael Silbert had hidden even from Huginn, his right-hand man.

A monster.

Yes.

That was what The Prophet really was.

"H-he left behind a message."

The monster called The Prophet was dangling bait in front of me.

On a high, moundlike hill, an old man in a turban watched a hazy cloud of sand rise not far away.

More precisely, he watched the dozens of vehicles visible through it.

"Shall we eliminate them?"

At his subordinate's voice, which came from empty air, the old man asked calmly, "How many?"

"We estimate more than five hundred."

"Any S-rank Hunters among them?"

"Not that we've been able to determine. Even if there are, I could wipe them all out if I went in."

The old man stroked his coarse beard. He fell silent in thought, and only after a short while did he speak.

"Leave them be."

"But the distance…"

"Hamid, did you not hear me?"

After a moment's silence at the sudden call, the subordinate answered, "I'm sorry, Amir. I was out of line."

"Restrain your hot blood and wait for the time that is soon to come. Did The Prophet not say as much? Everything will unfold according to his will."

The old man reached out and felt around in the air. Something invisible was protecting them from the infidels.

That was why even satellites in orbit couldn't detect them—and why the infidels couldn't find them despite drawing within a few kilometers.[3208]

No, the infidels wouldn't find them even if they came right up to them.

Unless they lifted this veil and stepped out themselves, no one could see or sense them. And if that moment came, it would be the intruder's last moment alive.

This mysterious power could only be thought of as divine protection.

Their god had sent The Prophet down to earth in his place, and The Prophet would lead them to the promised land.

They would punish the wicked infidels and establish God's will across every land and sea.

"Do not be impatient. As long as The Prophet is with us, victory in this great holy war will be ours."

"But where is The Prophet now…?"

"He will come of his own accord soon. Do not doubt it. With the net God has laid, he will gather up every last one of those infidels and send them to God."

"…!"

"Inshallah."

The old man murmured it once more, his reverence swelling.

Inshallah.

God willing.

[3208] A kilometer is about 0.62 mi, so a few kilometers is roughly a few miles.

Chapter 800

Hunters lived close to death.

It made no difference whether they were S-rank Hunters known around the world or F-rank Hunters as common as stones in the street. No one was exempt.

The misfortune of death came equally to everyone, and Hunters were more accustomed to that fact than anyone.

But…

“Holy shit.”

The quiet curse spoke for everyone.

Reflected in dozens of pairs of eyes, trembling slightly in that moment, were around two hundred corpses, shriveled nearly to nothing.

“Damn it. Has anyone here ever seen anything this insane, even once?”

No one answered the Team Leader. More accurately, they’d forgotten how.

What the hell is this?

They might have been assigned to recover the dead in the rear, but they were Hunters all the same. They’d had more than their share of brushes with death and seen more corpses than they cared to remember.

Especially after the series of events that had unfolded one after another over the past few months. How many deaths had they witnessed?

And yet, even they couldn’t help feeling a chill run down their spines at that moment.

“…Didn’t you say they’d been dead for less than two hours?”

The Team Leader bit his lip at the question that broke the long silence.

“It’s hard to believe, but yes. That’s exactly what I was told.”

“Then it’s one of two things. Either you’re deaf, Team Leader, or whoever told you is insane.”

“Could be. But neither is true.”

“Maybe not. But looking at these bodies, I’d say they’ve been dead for at least a couple of centuries. What kind of lunatic told you they’d been dead for less than two hours?”

“What, you planning to go argue with them?”

“We ought to check whether it’s true. And if they were talking nonsense, I’ll punch them right in the face.”

“Fine.”

The Team Leader had taken out a cigarette and put it between his lips. He went on calmly.

"If you really want to, head to the command tent right now. Punch Magic Johnson in the face as soon as you see him. Don't worry about what happens afterward—I'll recover your bodies and take them home to your families."

"What?"

"Still here? You said you were going to find that lunatic and punch him."

"…"

The Hunters were speechless.

It wasn't so much that the lunatic they'd just been cursing was Magic Johnson. The greater shock came from the realization that the order itself wasn't wrong.

So it's all true?

Damn it. What's going on?

Becoming a veteran Hunter meant knowing the smell of blood better than the smell of pancakes cooking. It meant seeing enough horrors to qualify as an undertaker if you ever quit.

Limbs severed, torsos torn apart, heads crushed…

They'd seen it all more times than they could count. Most of the corpses they'd encountered belonged to monsters, but plenty had belonged to comrades they'd shared meals with, too.

Even so, they'd never seen bodies like these.

Around two hundred corpses, dried out without a drop of blood left in them.

If they hadn't known what had happened, every last one of them would have thought they'd been sent to excavate ruins.

These weren't just corpses. They looked like mummies that had been buried deep underground for centuries.

Damn it. Have we been bewitched?

They've been like this for less than two hours? How is that possible?

They weren't gruesome so much as bizarre.

Every moment sent goose bumps crawling over their bodies. They couldn't take even one step toward those corpses, with not a trace of life left in them.

And the same question filled every mind.

What did this to them?

Not *who*. *What*.

As everyone swallowed hard at the thought of an unknown enemy they couldn't even begin to predict, the Team Leader took a deep drag on his cigarette and shouted,

"Fuck! How long are you going to stand there staring? Stop wasting time thinking about it and get moving! Now!"

The Hunters jolted as if they'd just woken up. At last, they began to move, though their steps were slow.

As he watched his subordinates force themselves toward the corpses, the Team Leader suddenly realized he hadn't lit his cigarette.

...Damn it.

He cursed under his breath and threw it to the ground.

But his hand, now brushing over his parched lips, was trembling slightly.

"Rumors are spreading."

Team Leader Choi's face was grave.

"Everyone's afraid. Word about the fallen Hunters' bodies is circulating quietly."

"..."

"We need to do something before it gets any worse. If this continues..."

His voice trailed off, but I knew what he meant.

I finished the sentence Team Leader Choi couldn't.

We'll fall apart from the inside before we even get moving.

He wasn't talking about another traitor like Michael Silbert emerging.

He meant the force an army depended on to function: morale.

Fear's eating away at them. Fast.

Some things couldn't be stopped, no matter how hard you tried.

Like this.

"There were too many witnesses. We ordered them not to talk, but there's only so much we can do to contain the rumors."

Even an order to keep quiet had its limits.

The J1 team Yamamoto Genji belonged to had been wiped out in a bizarre fashion. Hundreds of people had reached the scene before I did.

Even the authority my name carried couldn't seal every one of their mouths.

People's emotions.

Human emotions—especially fear—were beyond anyone's control.

But the bigger problem was that the rumors frightening even veteran Hunters who'd been through hell and back weren't baseless nonsense.

"And although these stories haven't gained much traction yet..."

Team Leader Choi hesitated, then continued with a sigh.

"Some people have started embellishing what happened. They're spreading all kinds of nonsense."

"Like what?"

"That The Prophet really is God's chosen representative. Or a transcendent being like the Demon King Asmodeus..."

Bang!

“Bullshit!”

Magic Johnson shot to his feet with a shout, his eyes blazing.

“Tell me, Choi. Who the hell is spreading this deranged crap?”

“Like I said, it hasn’t gained much traction. It’s one of several stories going around, so we can’t point to anyone in particular. The problem is that a tiny number of people genuinely believe it.”

“What kind of world do they think we live in, believing superstitious crap like that… Damn it.”

Magic Johnson started to say something, then shut his mouth with a rough curse.

The hulking Grand Mage had clearly remembered something he’d forgotten for a moment.

That Hunters were more obsessed with superstition than anyone else in the world.

In a way, it was only natural. Whatever their reasons for becoming Hunters, they were human. They wanted to survive.

They might gain wealth beyond an ordinary person’s dreams and the honor of being humanity’s sword and shield. But survival came first.

Even athletes kept strange routines no one else understood and clung to childish superstitions. How could Hunters, who fought with their lives on the line, be any different?

Athletes might believe a superstition would save their careers. For Hunters, it was their lives at stake.

Especially when they faced an unknown phenomenon that no one had ever encountered before.

“A Demon King, of all things. What a bunch of idiots.”

I looked at the Skeleton King, who muttered in disbelief.

He’d already gotten a similar look from me several times, so he immediately understood what it meant and furrowed his brow.

“I told you. I don’t know either.”

That wasn’t the answer I’d wanted.

I tried to hide my disappointment. “Right. That’s why I gave you time to think.”

“…Damn it. I’m genuinely curious, too. What the hell is that guy called The Prophet?”

The Skeleton King sighed and went on.

“But what am I supposed to do if I don’t know? I first became conscious in that place you call a Gate. Everything before that is blurry. No, I can’t even call it a memory.”

“Not even fragments?”

“A dark, ominous place. That’s all I can recall. Perhaps it was the Demon Realm. Another world beyond the Gate. Isn’t that right?”

No one could answer him. Not me, not Magic Johnson—not anyone in humanity.

Ever since the Demon King Asmodeus descended into this world, humanity had known of the land of death beyond the dimensions. Yet from the moment we learned it existed, the place itself had remained shrouded in mystery.

No one knew what was there or what calamities lived within it.

Not even the Skeleton King, who had come through a Gate from the Demon Realm.

"What I know is only a tiny fraction. Do you know what surprised me most after I set foot in this world?"

I answered without thinking. "Clubs?"

"…What exactly do you think of me?"

"Illegal immigrant. Dumbass. Eunuch."

The Skeleton King gave me a look that had gone completely cold, then sighed deeply.

"Damn it. Yes, clubs were a hell of a surprise too. But what amazed me most was the Monster Encyclopedia you humans made."

"What?"

"That was when I first realized there were so many different kinds of monsters. Until then, what I knew about monsters amounted to a scrap of flesh on a pile of bones."

"…!"

"But even you humans, who've spent so long researching monsters, haven't uncovered everything. Isn't that right?"

Magic Johnson answered, his face set. "That's true. There were limits to what we could learn by studying monsters."

These days, it was the kind of story you only read in history textbooks.

Even after the Great Cataclysm, humanity wanted more data. In the period immediately after the war ended, Hunters weren't hunting monsters so much as capturing them.

Then came all kinds of experiments, including dissections.

But that wasn't enough. Not every monster in the world was a low-level one like a goblin.

"The more powerful the monsters we tried to capture, the greater our losses. Plenty of S-rank Hunters joined the effort, myself included, but we didn't always succeed."

"Which means…"

"Among the highest-level monsters we most wanted to target, some Named monsters like Leviathan and the Arch Lich had disappeared completely. And there were monsters like Dragons, with very few individuals. We weren't able to learn much about those."

I murmured, “The Prophet could be one of them.”

“Right. If he really is a monster, as we suspect… he must be one of the top-level Named monsters we never identified.”

Magic Johnson’s voice sank.

“And I can say this for certain: from the Great Cataclysm until now, I’ve never seen anything with an ability like his.”

He was a complete unknown.

We knew neither what he was nor what he could do.

And fighting an enemy whose nature you hadn’t uncovered was the stupidest, craziest thing you could do.

Of course, I’d done that crazy thing countless times.

“Then there’s only one option left.”

At my offhand remark, I saw everyone’s expression grow heavy. Before anyone could try to stop me, I continued.

“We set out immediately. I have to see that bastard’s face.”

One message.

I would use those words The Prophet had sent me through Yamamoto Genji as a signpost and track the bastard down.

Before an irreversible catastrophe struck.

Even if… it was a trap.

Chapter 801

“We’re leaving soon. Get ready.”

At that one remark, tossed out when I came back without warning, Yamamoto Genji surprisingly nodded obediently.

“Understood.”

For a guy who’d been going on about Chōsenjin[3209] when he first woke up, he was being about as polite as possible.

If Heo Jun had witnessed this astonishing change, he might have written this on the first line of the *Donguibogam*[3210]:

> A beating is the best medicine.

Bodily wounds called for potions. A rotten mind called for fists.

Yamamoto Genji scrambled out of bed and snapped to attention like a recruit.

“I’m ready.”

“Already?”

“Yes, sir.”

“You planning to fight in that?”

“Huh?”

Yamamoto Genji blinked. From that innocent look, he clearly hadn’t understood what I meant. Or maybe he hadn’t heard me properly.

So I kindly repeated myself.

“You planning to fight in your hospital gown?”

“…!”

A brief silence.

At last, he realized what I meant by *leaving*. His voice trembled.

“W-we’re going to the battlefield?”

“Where did you think we were going?”

“I’m still a patient, so I naturally assumed I’d be sent back to the main camp…”

“Sent back?”

“Y-yes, sir.”

“Hmm. Right. You’re still a patient. A patient.”

Good grief. I’d forgotten something important.

Muttering to myself, I kicked open the firmly shut door.

[3209] *Chōsenjin* is a Japanese term for Koreans that can be used derogatorily.

[3210] The *Donguibogam* is a seventeenth-century Korean medical encyclopedia compiled by Heo Jun, a royal physician of the Joseon dynasty.

“Hey! Anyone out there?”

A healer from the medical unit came running before the words had left my mouth.

“Yes, sir.”

“Uh, the transport vehicle going back to the main camp hasn’t left yet, right?”

“No, sir. It’s still waiting.”

“Good. Contact the team leader right away and tell him to load one more body. I’ll take care of the cleanup, so all they have to do is come pick him up.”

“I’ll pass that along.”

“…Wait.”

Yamamoto Genji had been listening. Now he looked distinctly uneasy.

“One more body? Cleanup? What does that mean?”

“Nothing. Don’t worry about it.”

“It sounds like something I should worry about. Hey, you. Put down the phone. Who are you calling?”

The healer answered flatly, “Team Leader Jones, as the boss instructed.”

“Who’s Team Leader Jones?”

“He’s in charge of recovering the dead. He transports the fallen back to the main camp.”

“…!”

Yamamoto Genji looked from me to the healer and back. Then his expression turned resolute.

“On my honor as a samurai, I’ll give my life in battle.”

“What honor? I looked you up online. Your nickname’s ‘Swift No-Show.‘”

“…”

“Quit talking bullshit. Gear up and get out here.”

“Yes, sir. But, by any chance…”

“What?”

“I’m still not feeling well. Is there really no way you could send me to the rear…”

Whack!

“Ugh!”

Even now, all he could think about was running away. A bastard like this needed a beating.

I sighed and watched him stagger to his feet.

I’d have loved to beat the hell out of him, but the fact that I needed even a piece of shit like him left a bad taste in my mouth.

“Hey.”

“W-why? What is it?”

“I’m not going to hit you, so relax. I just want to check one more time.”

My voice dropped.

“What you said he told you back then. Are you sure?”

Before Yamamoto Genji could answer, the words I’d already heard several times replayed in my ears.

> “Rub’ al Khali. Come find me in the land where the black jewel sleeps, before it’s too late.”

The trailing hem of The Prophet’s long robe seemed close enough to grab.

The Arabian Desert covers most of the Middle East, stretching from Yemen through Oman and the Persian Gulf to Jordan and Iraq.

More than 2.3 million square kilometers.[3211] Korea’s official area, as submitted to the UN, was just over 200,000 square kilometers.[3212] By comparison, the desert was absurdly vast.

No wonder the estimated search time was so long. We were planning to comb through all this.

But we’d had no other choice.

Mana readings rose by the day, and the concentration had grown so dense that even the most advanced equipment couldn’t function properly. Covering that much ground meant sending a hundred thousand Hunters out on foot.

Then The Prophet, who’d been hiding somewhere in that vast desert, named a place himself. Whether that was good news or bad, I couldn’t say.

The Rub’ al Khali Desert.

If the Arabian Desert was the broad term for the desert regions of the Middle East, the Rub’ al Khali was the vast desert at its center, spread across the southern Arabian Peninsula.

It was the second-largest desert in the world, after the Sahara in Africa. Even so, narrowing down the area The Prophet meant wasn’t difficult.

At least, not for Team Leader Choi.

“The Empty Quarter.”

“What’s that?”

“Rub’ al Khali means ‘Empty Quarter’ in Arabic. A land where no one can live. Nothing but blazing sun and sand. That’s probably how it got such a desolate name.”

“Then the black jewel…”

[3211] More than 2.3 million square kilometers is more than about 890,000 square miles.

[3212] Just over 200,000 square kilometers is just over about 77,000 square miles.

"There are oil fields there. Supposedly, they were once the largest in the world. Judging by his message, that's our likeliest destination."

Searching was the hard part. Getting there wasn't. Once we had a destination, we advanced at astonishing speed.

The thousand Hunters chosen for the expedition were among the best deployed to the Middle East. We took the shortest route across the Arabian Desert and reached the Rub' al Khali.

And we immediately understood why the people of the ancient Middle East had called this place the Empty Quarter.

Desert and wilderness stretched to the horizon like a vast sea, with small villages scattered through it like reefs.

Machinery and abandoned industrial complexes stood among them. The place was so desolate that it was hard to believe the world's largest oil field had once been here.

Even the Skeleton King blinked in confusion.

"What? Humans live here? This isn't a Gate?"

Team Leader Choi had said *once* for a reason.

This land had been abandoned twice.

Once, long ago, when its inhabitants named it the Rub' al Khali. Then again during the Great Cataclysm.

And a place didn't get abandoned without reason.

"Spectacular."

I wished Magic Johnson, who'd come with us, had said that. Unfortunately, it was the Skeleton King. I could feel what he meant, though.

Maybe we all did.

The concentration of magical power... It's too dense.

At some point, the air had grown heavy. It wasn't just the sun beating down on us.

Clunk. Psssh.

An engine died abruptly. The vehicles carrying our thousand Hunters all ground to a halt, and Magic Johnson murmured, "Here we go."

A simple mechanical failure was out of the question.

Yamamoto Genji had been through something similar before. His face was already deathly pale.

"He's here. He's here. He's here..."

The Skeleton King watched him mutter without pause, then turned to me.

"Can I kill that human?"

"No. Unfortunately, you can't."

"Why not? Didn't we bring him along to put his body to use? If I have to keep looking at him like that, I might as well turn him into an undead."

"Oh."

Was this bastard a genius?

I barely stopped myself from nodding at his surprisingly logical argument. Then I gave Yamamoto Genji a hard kick and got out of the vehicle.

What do you mean, he's here already?

We were still a considerable distance from the oil fields The Prophet had hinted at. Apart from the rising concentration of magical power, I hadn't sensed anything unusual.

This was only a sign.

An ominous but unmistakable sign that something we hadn't encountered yet was out there in the vast desert.

Then the specialist checking the magical-power distribution at regular intervals gave his report, turning my suspicion into certainty.

"We can't get a reading. Our equipment can't determine an accurate value."

Not even with several precious A-rank Magic Gems fitted into the measuring device.

I licked my dry lips.

"He told us to come find him. Guess he wasn't just talking bullshit."

Team Leader Choi stepped quietly up beside me.

"Should we pull back and request reinforcements while we still can?"

A cautious suggestion, just like him. I shook my head without hesitation.

"No. We keep going."

"We don't know what kind of trap may be waiting."

"Of course there could be a trap. We know what that bastard Prophet is like."

"Then why…"

"Trap or not, we have to break through. We don't have time. And…"

I lowered my voice.

"If luring us here is his goal in itself, that's all the more reason not to call for reinforcements."

We didn't know the limits of The Prophet's abilities or One God's fighting strength. Calling S-rank Hunters here—the core of our forces—would put everyone left behind in danger.

In this desert, The Prophet was practically a pope with countless fanatics at his command.

It'd be a problem if we brought in reinforcements only to leave the rear wide open to a raid.

That didn't mean I planned to fight recklessly.

Normally, I would've gone alone. The reason I'd brought a thousand Hunters was that I knew I wasn't invincible, no matter how strong I was. Nothing was more dangerous than an enemy you didn't understand.

And the force we had now was neither too small nor too large.

Even without me, we had two dependable powerhouses in Magic Johnson and the Skeleton King. Add the cowardly Yamamoto Genji and Team Leader Choi, and I was sure we could smash our way through whatever came.

Bring in more forces, though, and he might run.

We held the front, while Chuck Hagel, Faye Chen, Prince Felix, and several other S-rank Hunters guarded the encirclement with a considerable force to our rear.

If we added or removed even a little from either side, the balance of power would shift—and our chance to eliminate The Prophet would slip that much farther away.

"No beast attacks something that looks stronger than itself. Especially not a fox like The Prophet. Right, Jin?"

"That's right."

I nodded at Magic Johnson, watching the heat haze rise over the distant desert.

"Still, that's a relief. Looks like that quick-witted fox hasn't gotten scared and run off."

"What do you mean—!"

His face went rigid in an instant.

Realizing what I meant, Magic Johnson hurriedly swallowed the rest of his words and shouted, pouring his mighty mana into his voice.

"Prepare for battle!"

Right.

They were coming.

Chapter 802

Slide.

Sand slipped slowly down the hillside. The day was sweltering, without a breath of wind. Beneath the blazing sun, the shadows of flying beasts passed over everyone's heads.

Kreeeaaak!

A dozen or so eagles glided through the sky, their cries almost like screams.

Their enormous wings, spanning several meters,[3213] were nothing but bare white bones. The eyes gazing down from far above were not made of flesh and blood. They burned with a vivid blue light.

The gaze of something returned from the edge of death.

Something caught between life and death.

"Undead…"

The word escaped someone's lips like a sigh.

Yet none of the people watching the eagles fly overhead and on toward the horizon looked afraid. They already knew the undead monsters weren't their enemies.

More precisely, they knew the creatures' master was on their side.

And at least one of them thought of him as more than an ally. He was a friend.

"Hey."

"What? Don't talk to me. I'm concentrating."

"How's it going?"

"I said don't talk to me. I'm sharing my vision."

"Still? You're damn slow."

"Fuck it. I'm done."

"Sorry."

"Then shut your mouth, you lunatic. Do you think this is some cheap Familiar like the ones humans use?"

His voice was curt. The human and the monster spoke as casually as old friends while staring into the heat haze shimmering over the desert.

Beneath them, vibrations slowly crumbled the sand dunes.

"Anything yet?"

"No. Actually, I finished a little while ago."

"What? Why didn't you say so?"

"To build suspense."

"You're a nutcase."

[3213] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

“I’m kidding. I didn’t say anything because I wasn’t sure how to tell you.”

“…There are that many?”

“Yes.”

“How many?”

“At least ten thousand. After that, there were too many, so I gave up counting.”

At the Skeleton King’s answer, Jin Taekyung fell silent.

Ten thousand.

An enormous army.

And that was only how many the Skeleton King had confirmed. The true number might be far higher.

“Fuck. They really went all out.”

“They had a reason for drawing us all the way here.”

“What about him?”

The Skeleton King knew who Jin meant by *him*. He shook his head.

“I still don’t know. From above, there are about three that look like serious threats, but whether one of them is The Prophet… Hmm.”

The Skeleton King let out a low groan. His expression stiffened as he continued.

“There was one in the air, too.”

“All S-rank?”

“Probably. My servants were taken out before they could do a thing.”

Three on the ground. One in the air.

The news that four S-rank monsters had led an army of tens of thousands right to their doorstep shook the nearly one thousand Hunters. However carefully selected and battle-hardened they were, they couldn’t simply stop fearing death.

Thud. Rumble, rumble.

The vibrations grew stronger. The Hunters’ gazes trembled as they watched the sand shift beneath their feet.

They could almost see the countless monsters about to surge toward them like a wave.

And amid the monsters’ roars and the fierce fighting, they could see their comrades—or themselves—dying in sprays of blood.

Then a calm voice reached them.

“So, want to retreat now?”

One by one, those who’d been staring at the ground raised their heads. Jin Taekyung stood on the hill, watching them with a steady, solemn gaze.

“No. I guess we should call it running away, not retreating. Right?”

“…!”

“Honestly, whether you call it a strategic retreat or running away, I can’t blame you. Everyone wants to survive. Everyone has a reason to keep living, even if they have to run like hell to do it.”

That was true of everyone.

People had family bound to them by blood, and friends who were family in all but blood. Even those who had neither still had reasons to go on living.

But…

“I don’t know where it came from, but there’s a saying: There’s no paradise at the end of the road when you run away.”

It was strange.

The sun overhead was hot enough to set them on fire, yet the moment they heard Jin Taekyung’s voice, a chill went through them as though they’d been doused in cold water.

He was right.

There was no paradise at the end of the road when you ran away. They lived in a time like that.

“Run, and run, and keep running… Then one day, after doing everything you can to stay alive, you look around. Will there be anything left for you to protect?”

It had been some thirty years.

Humanity had rebuilt bigger, grander cities on the ruins left by the Great Cataclysm. The disaster’s traces remained only in records and scars.

Those who survived the war, or were born after peace arrived, didn’t know what war was like.

But Jin Taekyung was different.

“Once you start backing down, it’s over.”

A battle was not a war. A Gate was not the real world.

In the Gates they’d faced until now, they could retreat to avoid a fight. But the place where they stood now was the world where they’d been born and raised.

A world with something they had to protect.

A world they had to protect, no matter what.

Jin Taekyung had known that since the day he survived alone, leaving behind someone who’d been like an older brother. He knew it still, now that he’d come to know another world.

“If there’s something you want to protect, put your life on the line and fight. That’s why you’re here, isn’t it?”

Everyone wondered, but no one knew why the cursed monsters had invaded this world—or how humans had come to possess such incredible power.

But they all had some inkling.

The power that had come to them one day like a stroke of luck had been given to them to protect this world from monsters.

"And for that one reason…"

Whoosh.

Sand whipped around Jin Taekyung. A hot wind blew in from somewhere and swept over the people.

It thawed their hands and feet, frozen despite the scorching sun, and set the red blood in their veins boiling—blood unlike that of the monsters now emerging in the distance through a vast sandstorm.

"That's why people—why this world—calls us Hunters."

Fwoosh!

An immense wave of qi jolted everyone alert. Heat haze rose around Jin Taekyung as he slowly turned.

The heat was so intense that the space around him seemed to warp.

His spearhead caught the sunlight and blazed like a blue-white sun.

"Get into formation."

Clang, clang, clang!

Countless weapons came free at once, as if on cue.

Magic Johnson raised his staff, and dozens of transport vehicles, each weighing several metric tons,[3214] moved across their front to form a barricade.

Behind them, nearly a hundred tanks drove tower shields larger than their own bodies deep into the sand.

Boom. Rumble!

A wall of steel took shape amid heavy thuds.

And then…

Rumble…

A wave of monsters raced across the boundless desert, throwing up a vast cloud of sand.

Jin Taekyung watched them come. His next words were so matter-of-fact that they took everyone by surprise.

"Fuck. Hang in there, everyone. Killing all those bastards is going to be a real pain in the ass."

Someone burst out laughing. A Hunter who'd been staring at the comrade beside him as if he'd gone mad let out a short laugh, too. Soon everyone's shoulders were shaking.

Kill them all? Every last one of those monsters?

Ordinarily, they'd have thought it was ridiculous nonsense.

[3214] One metric ton is 1,000 kg, or about 2,205 lb.

If anyone else had said it, no matter how great a Hunter they were, they'd have cursed them under their breath.

But that startlingly young Asian man was Jin Taekyung, the new Alliance Leader of the World Hunter Federation.

A hero who had proven himself.

The only person writing a new legend after Cheon Taemin.

They couldn't help believing in him. Jin Taekyung had always fought at the very front, harder than anyone else.

That alone was reason enough to fight.

Boom. Rumble, rumble!

Graaaar!

Even as the rumbling and roars swelled until their eardrums throbbed, the Hunters couldn't stop laughing.

From the sand dune, where he stood as solid as a mountain, Jin Taekyung swung his spear.

Crunch!

Blood shot up like a fountain and evaporated before it touched the ground. Torn bodies and entrails scattered in every direction.

It was the opening moment of the great battle that would later be called the Desert Storm.

Chuck Hagel stared silently at the cigar in his hand.

The cigar he'd taken—or rather, acquired—from the French President not long ago was still burning down.

He'd since heard it had been a gift from Michael Silbert himself. Given where it came from, it was obviously worth a fortune.

Cuban cigars made before the Great Cataclysm were impossible to find now, no matter how much money you had.

Why?

Simple. Cuba had been destroyed.

The Monster Wave that began in the center of Cuba's capital had grown beyond control. It ended only after sinking three island nations in the Cayman Islands deep beneath the sea.

Perhaps that was when it started.

When a certain middle-aged man who'd never touched tobacco began smoking cigars out of habit.

His mother had been in Cuba.

Crackle.

Ash that had been burning for a long time dropped with a soft *tap*.

After watching it in silence for a long while, Chuck Hagel abruptly spoke.

“Any request for backup?”

His aide waved away the thick cigar smoke before answering.

“Not yet.”

“Goddamn it.”

“You don’t need to worry so much, boss.”

“Worry? About that punk?”

He’s too strong to call a punk. And he’s your superior, too.

The aide barely kept the words from slipping out. He clicked his tongue instead.

“We’re fully prepared and standing by. We have the rear of the Rub’ al Khali Desert covered.”

“Damn it. That’s all well and good, but that goddamn satellite surveillance still doesn’t work. Why are the drones down? Did some defense contractor take a kickback?”

“Come on, boss. You know why. The concentration of magical power is too high.”

“I don’t know a damn thing about that. What I do know is that if anything happens to the others with that punk who ran off on his own… the bastards who made those fucking paper airplanes will die by my hand.”

“…”

The aide was profoundly grateful that there was no one from a defense contractor around at that moment.

He was grateful, too, that his short-tempered superior was still guarding the main force.

Unfortunately, his relief didn’t last long.

Beep. Beep-beep.

“…Huh?”

An emergency alarm sounded without warning, and red warning lights flashed on. Urgent shouts broke out across the command center.

“Identify the sender and the coordinates!”

“Damn it! Hurry!”

A moment later, Chuck Hagel saw his aide’s face stiffen as he read the report.

“What is it?”

“…We’re under attack. Part of the search party outside has been hit.”

“What?”

“And…”

The aide paused for breath, then let it out.

“The enemy isn’t a monster.”

Chapter 803

Human beings possess almost limitless potential.

With minds more capable than those of any other living thing on Earth, they built systems of their own and developed civilization.

From the primitive prehistoric age to the present, what humans had achieved was dazzling—especially the history and culture they had built over the past several thousand years.

Progress, progress, and more progress.

Humans never stopped discovering new things. With each discovery, they moved forward.

Until gunfire filled battlefields where swords and spears had once clashed. Until car horns replaced the whinny of horses on streets lit by neon signs.

Until they crossed five seas and six continents and finally ventured into space.

“Houston, Tranquility Base here. The Eagle has landed.”

On the day that grand plan, named after an ancient sun god, succeeded, what did the god watching from somewhere think? A human had set foot on the moon for the first time and called that historic moment “one small step, one giant leap for mankind.”

No one could know the will of God. But an old man with the rather long name Abdullah bin Abdulaziz Ali was certain.

God must have been enraged.

Otherwise, He would not have unleashed a great flood called the Great Cataclysm.

Sending the great Prophet down to this land and commanding him to punish them surely meant that he was to punish humanity’s arrogance on God’s behalf.

“Do you not think so too, sinful infidel?”

“…!”

The middle-aged man trembled at the old man’s calm voice.

Drenched in blood, he stood amid his many subordinates. Only moments ago, they had been alive and breathing. Now they lay strewn across the ground.

He had nothing left but the sword in his hand and the mana boiling through his body, his fighting spirit still undiminished.

“Atone through death. Like those who went before you.”

“Go… fuck yourself!”

With a shout like a scream, the middle-aged man drew on every ounce of his strength and charged the old fanatic.

Whoooosh!

A strike that would likely be his last.

His sword flew faster than ever before, its blade blazing with aura.

Shhk!

A flash came out of nowhere, cleaving both the aura-wreathed sword and its wielder in two.

Splatter!

Blood gushed like a fountain.

As the headless corpse crumpled, something glinting fell at the old man's feet.

A necklace. It was a necklace.

The old man stared at the crucifix necklace half-buried in the hot sand, then spoke.

"Any survivors?"

"None. That infidel was the last."

The young man who had cut down the middle-aged A-rank Hunter as easily as breathing continued, "Amir, there are more infidels not far from here. If you let me go…"

"Their main force will have heard from them over the radio this time. We've dealt with them easily so far, but it won't be that simple from now on."

"No matter how strong the infidels' forces are, we can defeat them!"

"You're right, Hamid, son of Hassan. But have you forgotten what the Prophet said?"

Hamid flinched at the old man's piercing gaze. A moment later, he realized what Amir meant, and his eyes widened.

"What the Prophet said… Could it be?"

"Yes. The time has finally come. The time promised by the Prophet and almighty Allah is upon us."

"…!"

Surprise turned to joy. Joy to fervor.

The old man smiled as he watched Hamid's expression change. Then he looked over the warriors of God surrounding them and murmured, "Inshallah.[3215] The Prophet will lead us to the promised land!"

"Inshallah![3216]"

"Allah hu akbar![3217]"

Their voices rose together in a mighty shout. The countless fanatics who had lain dormant deep in the desert for decades began their advance.

Toward the promised land they had awaited for so long.

Toward the place overflowing with God's grace.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

A vast cloud of sand swept across the desert.

[3215] *Inshallah* is an Arabic expression meaning "God willing."

[3216] *Inshallah* is an Arabic expression meaning "God willing."

[3217] *Allah hu akbar* is an Arabic phrase meaning "God is greatest."

If this world were a chessboard, what would my role be?

A pawn that could only move forward?

A knight that could go farther than a pawn?

A bishop crossing the board diagonally?

Maybe a rook moving in straight lines, a queen with the combined reach of a bishop and a rook, or the king—ironically, the most important piece and yet weaker than the queen.

Honestly, I didn't know.

Even now, as the Alliance Leader of the World Hunter Federation, even with everyone in the world knowing who I was, I still didn't know exactly where I stood.

What I could do on this chessboard, or how far I could go.

But one thing I could say for sure.

If that chessboard was a battlefield rather than the world, I could dominate it.

I could push forward like a pawn, leap over my enemies' heads like a knight, then range across the board like a bishop, rook, or queen and swallow everything in my path.

Just like right now.

Baaang!

Flesh and bone burst apart before the spearhead even touched them. A Troll with its upper half blown away toppled like a rotten log, and someone shouted behind me.

"Damn it! How many times do I have to tell you? Kill them like that and I can barely use them as undead!"

Instead of answering, I twisted my body.

Whoom. Boom!

Three flails flying in from different directions tangled together.

—Kwo?

The ogres blinked stupidly, a beat too late to understand what had happened.

White Flame's spearhead had already swept past their necks.

Shhk!

Three heads flew free of their massive bodies.

I sprang off an ogre's lifeless corpse and plunged toward the monsters packed around me.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, Form Two.

Heavenly Strike.

Krrrunch!

Blood sprayed. Flesh split.

Ding. Ding, ding.

System alerts rang in my ears without pause as I leaped into the thick cloud of dust.

Open Inventory.

One weapon stored, another summoned at the same instant.

Pop.

White Flame vanished from my hand like an illusion. In its place, two short daggers settled firmly into my hands.

In a fight at this close range, they were faster and more efficient than any divine weapon.

I'd watched someone wield a dagger like this up close. With a single blade, he had earned the name Slaughter Saint.

And I watched him do it from right beside him.

For one brief moment, I steadied my breathing.

I calmed the internal energy pounding as though it would burst out of me. Light on my toes. Shoulders loose.

Remembering the Slaughter Saint's advice, I copied the movements I'd seen him perform right in front of me dozens of times.

Then I took a step.

Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step.

Swish.

The wind that had always struck me head-on now slipped gently past.

I felt as though I were floating through the air in zero gravity.

Of course, I couldn't claim I'd perfectly copied the Slaughter Saint's personal martial art just by doing this much. But for dealing with these bastards right now, this much was enough.

Shhk, shhk, shhk!

The sound of slicing reached my ears only after flesh and bone had been cut.

Sound wasn't slow.

I was fast enough to leave it behind. So were the daggers in my hands.

Thud, thud, thud!

I slipped among the monsters like mist, my daggers stabbing and slashing in flashes. Dozens fell, spraying blood.

No—they fell and rose again at the same moment.

—In the king's name, I command you: answer the call.

Whoooooosh.

A voice seemed to ring inside my head rather than reach my ears, and a chilling cold swept across the battlefield.

It raised the monsters that had fallen moments ago and those falling even now.

—Krr. Grrrk.

Slow, rasping cries.

An eerie light glimmered deep in their eyes.

Reborn as new beings at the edge of death, the undead army obeyed their king's command. Without hesitation, they charged the monsters pouring in from every direction.

—Kraaaaaa!

—Grr. Uh. Uh. Uh!

Thud. Kraaang!

The cries of living and undead monsters tangled together. Weapons swung hard into bodies on both sides.

But the living monsters felt pain. The undead had forgotten it when they died.

—Graaah.

Crunch! Splatter!

Outnumbered? It didn't matter.

Even when weapons took their limbs or pierced their chests, they kept moving to the very end.

The Skeleton King had given them only one goal: before the magical power he had bestowed on them ran out, before they died a second death, they were to create another soldier.

Crack!

—Kyaaaah!

A monster screamed as its throat was torn out.

The undead that had done it, already missing an arm and a leg, was ripped to shreds by enraged monsters. That didn't matter either.

Thanks to that, I—

No, we—had bought a little more time.

"Fire!"

"Fire Wall!"

"Lightning Spear!"

Fwoooosh.

Countless bolts of lightning and tongues of flame streaked through the air.

Behind the enormous transport vehicle blocking the way like a barricade, the monsters packed in so tightly there wasn't a gap—like the first day of an E-Mart[3218]

[3218] E-Mart is a South Korean hypermarket chain.

Black Friday sale—had no choice but to take the sudden barrage of attacks head-on.

Crackle. KRAAAASH!

—Kraaaaaa!

—Kgh! Grrrk!

Screams filled the air.

Lightning seared scales and flesh. Flames slipped through the gaps and burned bone and organs.

Many of the hundreds of monsters writhing in pain unlike anything they had ever felt even swung their weapons at their own allies.

—Kwoooooo!

Seized by their own savage instincts, the monsters charged one another.

But I didn’t let my guard down for a second.

“Hold formation! Don’t move a single step!”

I drove internal energy into the command. The Hunters who had begun advancing, swept up in the heat of battle and the thrill of gaining the upper hand, stopped in their tracks.

Battle was flow. Battle was momentum.

But there was a time to ride that momentum.

Against a force of well over ten thousand, taking out a mere thousand monsters wouldn’t win us the battle all at once.

Slowly. Carefully.

We had to win while keeping our losses to a minimum.

Besides…

I still can’t see him.

The bastard who had yet to show himself.

The Prophet.

And the S-rank monsters waiting for their moment among that sea of beasts—or somewhere in the sky above.

Until we took them down, neither this battle nor the war would end.

This fight… is only just beginning.

And at that moment, just as I muttered those words deep in my heart—

Thud. Thud. Thuuum.

An immense magical power surged from far away, making the desert tremble.

Chapter 804

Even when a thick fog hides the sea, anyone can tell there's an ocean beyond it. They can hear the faint cries of gulls and feel the salt in the wind.

A battlefield is the same.

Screams and blood fly in every direction. Countless blades clash, throwing off sparks. And yet, something with a special power can change the air of a battlefield simply by existing.

Just like now.

Rrrrmmm.

The air trembled.

A deep rumble rolling in from far away shook the desert.

The monsters that had been charging over the bodies of their own kind came to a halt as if on cue. People stiffened with a start.

What were they feeling at that moment?

A chill creeping down their spines? Or fear they'd briefly forgotten?

I didn't know exactly what it was, but I wasn't feeling either one.

What you saw depended on where you stood.

Unlike them, I stood on a peak. From there, I could see farther and sense more.

And I wasn't the only one.

"This is…"

The Skeleton King, who'd come up beside me at some point, murmured as if groaning.

Magic Johnson, who'd been saving his strength by focusing on defense in the rear, looked grim. So did Yamamoto Genji, an S-rank Hunter at least in name, and Team Leader Choi, whose Qi Sense was nearly as sharp as his.

"Fuck."

"Chikushō.[3219] This is insane. I have to get out of here."

"So the leaders are finally making their move."

Whack!

There's always a reason when some bastard gets hit.

I kicked Yamamoto Genji in the shin for spouting nonsense at a time like this. As I turned away, I stirred my internal energy and stamped down with a quake step.

Boom!

The ground shuddered around me, and a wall of sand surged upward.

Through the countless grains falling back down, I saw the Hunters' faces. They looked as if they'd just been doused in cold water.

[3219] *Chikushō* is a Japanese exclamation of frustration, roughly "damn it."

“What are you all scared of? You that eager to die?”

“B-but this is…”

“However you rank them, they’re still monsters. And we’re all still Hunters. So quit freezing up like you’re about to die and…”

Thud!

I drove a dagger into the head of an ogre still writhing and clinging stubbornly to life, then finished my sentence.

“Fight. Like Hunters.”

Ding.

SYSTEM

Defeated Lv. 95 Ogre!
Gained a tiny amount of EXP!
The effect of the Title One Against a Thousand activates!
Intimidation has greatly increased!
Enemies are rapidly losing confidence due to your Intimidation!
The status effect Fear, which had been applied to numerous allies, has been removed!
Ally morale has greatly increased. Those who follow your leadership will share a strong bond and perform even better!
Certain stats increase when facing numerous enemies!

One Against a Thousand was the Title I’d earned while fighting the Arch Lich’s army in Sichuan Province. For a reward earned through such a rare feat, it certainly delivered.

“GRAAAAAH!”

A few Hunters who’d been swallowing nervously until now roared, their eyes bloodshot. A tremendous cheer followed, heating the air around us.

Of course, there were always exceptions.

“No, even so, that was a bit much…”

I clicked my tongue softly at the sight of Yamamoto Genji rubbing his shin where I’d kicked it, watching me warily. Then I turned my eyes toward the monster army stretching endlessly across the vast desert.

Clack. Clack-clack.

Their movements were orderly now, unlike before.

A force of well over ten thousand marched with measured precision, parting to the left and right. Three paths opened, and at last, the beings radiating an overwhelming presence appeared.

The S-rank monsters.

Some were huge and grotesque. Others were so small compared to the monsters around them that they barely stood out.

But the demonic qi and Fear pouring from them were as overwhelming as all those countless monsters put together.

Enough to frighten even Yamamoto Genji. Cowardly and less capable though he was, he was still an S-rank Hunter.

“So those are the commanders leading this monster army,” the Skeleton King murmured.

“But the most important one is still missing,” I said.

“…The Prophet.”

“Right. The Prophet’s the head. Those guys are the hands and feet.”

“But is he here now? It pains me to admit it, but… I haven’t seen or sensed anyone I’d take to be The Prophet.”

To be honest, neither had I.

But there was one thing I was sure of.

The Prophet was somewhere on this battlefield.

Given how meticulous the bastard was, he was probably watching everything unfold from some distance away.

If he came close, I’d sense him right away.

The enemies were too numerous, and the battlefield too vast, for me to get a clear read with Qi Sense.

On top of that, the monster army’s momentum had changed with the arrival of its S-rank commanders. It was nothing like before.

“Jin.”

Magic Johnson’s low voice reached my ears. His eyes had sunk deep, as if he could already guess what the battle about to begin again would cost us.

He was worried about me, too—the one who would have to bear it all.

“If you’ll let me, I’d like to take command instead.”

I stared silently at Magic Johnson for a moment, then shook my head.

“No. I’m in command.”

Of course, Magic Johnson had the skill and the qualifications. He was a veteran of the Great Cataclysm and a fine commander who’d led his forces to victory in more than ten major battles.

But…

“If there’s something I have to bear, I won’t push it onto someone else.”

“…!”

“That’s one of the reasons I’m here, isn’t it?”

Magic Johnson looked at me with wide eyes, then gave a small nod.

When he spoke, I heard firm trust and the faintest trace of a smile.

“All right, young friend. Give us our orders.”

I took a deep breath and looked around at everyone.

A thousand Hunters in all. I didn’t know every name or every face.

But if someone fell here and never got back up, I’d remember everything about them for the rest of my life.

Yeah. That was enough.

If I died, they’d do the same for me.

“I’m dropping the formalities now, Magic Johnson.”

“Yes, young boss.”

“Keep the enemies in the air in check and focus on protecting our allies. The Hunters under you are to follow your orders until I say otherwise.”

“Yes, sir!”

Magic Johnson shouted his answer and rose into the air.

The Grand Mage’s eyes, alight with a keen edge, followed hundreds of specks slowly crossing the cloudless sky—and the eagle beating its wings at their head.

More precisely, he was watching a monster with enormous wings tens of meters[3220] across and a lion’s lower body: a Griffon.

“Choi Minwoo.”

“Yes.”

“Take a hundred troops and hold the front line. If the tanks break formation, hand in your sword and retire.”

Team Leader Choi raised the Hero’s Sword, its blade shining with transparent light, and answered.

“That won’t happen.”

Team Leader Choi was the great hero Cheon Taemin’s only blood descendant and the master of the Ares Guild, yet he’d never once slacked off.

Sometimes I thought that if a new S-rank Hunter emerged anytime soon, it would be him.

I let out a quiet laugh at his calm confidence, then turned to the others still waiting.

“Skeleton King. Yamamoto Genji. You two…”

“No need to waste time saying it. There are three S-rank monsters on the ground, so we can each take one.”

“M-me too?”

I silenced Yamamoto Genji with a hard stare, then corrected the Skeleton King.

“You and him take one each. I’ll take two.”

“What?”

[3220] Tens of meters is roughly 65–300 ft.

“Huh?”

The two of them questioned me at the same time. I turned away and muttered inwardly.

Open Inventory. Summon.

The two daggers that had served me so well in close combat disappeared. The cool, solid feel of a spear shaft filled my hand, which had been empty for an instant.

A flame warped the space around it.

Fwoosh.

Force formed around the transparent spearhead, wrapping it in a clear sheen.

In an instant too brief to measure, I gripped the spear in reverse and drove it down like a streak of light.

At an unseen enemy that had approached from deep in the desert without anyone noticing.

Shhk. KRAAAAAASH!

The heat-soaked ground split like tofu.

Hard sand and earth beneath my feet shot high into the air. In the ground, gouged out like a vast crater, countless writhing creatures came into view.

Among them was the largest of all, a monster gleaming red.

That’s…

A warning light flashed in my mind.

At the same time, the blue circle of Qi Sense spread out alongside my spearhead and reached the monster’s hard body.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

Your Qi Sense is currently at the eighth stage.
You have detected targets within range using Qi Sense!
Lv. 87 Soldier Scorpion
Lv. 76 Worker Scorpion
Lv. 99 Elite Scorpion

Countless details reached me through my eyes and ears.

But my attention was fixed on only one of them.

SYSTEM

Lv. 140 Scorpion King

Countless scorpions as large as grown men—and one scorpion larger than dozens of them put together.

The Scorpion King.

That was the enemy I had to take down first.

KRAAAAAASH! Crunch!

Superheated flames scorched the monsters' lair, deep beneath the ground.

Their hard carapaces, sharp pincers, even the venomous stingers on their tails—all of it melted away.

Kiiiiieeet!

The scorpions—or rather, the monsters—screamed in agony. Their dying cries spilled out of the pit and into the world.

Humans and monsters.

Monsters and humans.

Everyone could hear their screams, and everyone reacted.

"Kill. The. Humans!"

The Demon Realm language erupted like a roar from an S-rank monster, and a massive tremor swept in every direction.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

Their numbers weren't the problem.

Their momentum, and the quantity and quality of the demonic qi they emitted, were beyond comparison with what we'd faced before.

The elite monsters waiting in the rear charged after their S-rank commanders. More than ten thousand monsters surged behind them like a wave.

KRAAAAAH!

On the ground came an enormous force led by three S-rank monsters. Over everyone's heads, hundreds of flying monsters shrieked, led by the Griffon spreading its unusually large wings.

Kiaaaak!

The attack began across both sky and ground.

But I neither feared nor hesitated.

Kiaaaat!

The Scorpion King screamed as it burst out of the pit. I drove one decisive strike into it.

Crunch! Fwooooooosh!

Its acidic blood melted away in the flames.

Ding.

With the System alert I'd been waiting for, I charged like a beast toward the S-rank monsters.

KRAAAAAASH!

Chapter 805

A beast.

That was what Jin Taekyung looked like to everyone watching: fierce as a hungry tiger, majestic as a lion, swift as a leopard.

KRAAAAAASH!

Sand and earth swirled up around him. His figure seemed to ripple out of sight where he stood, then shot forward at terrifying speed.

Flamefire Path.

A single streak of flame crossed the space between them. He was faster than when he'd simply charged in headlong before, his movements incomparably more controlled.

Jin Taekyung felt he was beginning to understand, if only a little, the enlightenment the Fire King and the Slaughter Saint had reached over their lifetimes.

And how to bring down the enemies drawing closer by the second.

As the concentration of magical power had risen, so had these S-rank monsters' levels.

But Level wasn't an absolute measure of strength. An enemy with a lower Level might possess far greater qi, while one with a higher Level could be physically weaker.

Once opponents reached this tier, it ultimately came down to timing and matchup. Jin Taekyung had just turned the Level 140 Scorpion King into a roast with a surprise attack.

And there was only one way to size up an opponent's strength and find out how well you matched up.

Fight them.

Whoosh.

Several dozen meters[3221] vanished in an instant.

As Jin Taekyung charged straight at them, keeping his center of gravity low, three streaks of light fell toward him.

Shraaah!

[3221] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

The Death Knight's sword. The Lycanthrope's axe. And, last of all, the Manticore's claws.

Dark crimson magical power, so dense it seemed to warp space, pierced Jin Taekyung's body.

Or so the three S-rank monsters believed.

BOOM!

The earth flipped over with a deafening crash. Then a dark shadow fell overhead.

—…!

Their instincts awakened alongside the warning lights flashing in their minds.

These S-rank monsters were far too intelligent to dismiss as mere beasts. They understood at once what had happened, even as they struggled to accept what was right in front of them.

Power and qi greater than their own boiled inside that tiny, frail human body.

And then—

Heavenly Strike.

Jin Taekyung plunged toward the ground. Blue-white hellfire poured along White Flame's spearhead and swept out in every direction.

Fwoosh—KRAAAAAASH!

Flames spread as wide as a Grand Mage's Fire Wall spell, but burned hotter. They swallowed the front ranks of the monster army—horribly ravenous to behold, more ferocious than any beast.

—Aaaaaaagh!

—Kieeet!

Ding. Ding. Ding.

System alerts mingled with the dying screams of monsters.

But they weren't all that awaited Jin Taekyung as he rose from the blackened ash.

"How. Dare. You!"

The Lycanthrope Champion.

Trapped beneath the curse of the eternal moon, the strongest of the half-human, half-beast monsters roared and swung its enormous axe.

Whoooom!

Dark crimson magical power stormed through the air, cleaving space and wiping away the wind.

Just as the axe was about to split the human before it in two, White Flame's fire-wreathed spearhead flashed upward.

Clang!

A sharp ring sounded. The impossibly sturdy axe blade burst apart.

Crack—BOOM!

Hundreds of fragments rained down on the monsters rushing to save their commander.

Thud, thud, thud!

Screams rose with sprays of blood. Corpses piled atop corpses.

The Lycanthrope Champion stood frozen, bright yellow eyes wide. Jin Taekyung brought his spearhead down toward it without a moment's hesitation.

Or he would have, if not for the whistling sounds rushing in from both sides.

Whoooosh!

Jin Taekyung bent backward with lightning speed. His hair touched the ground as two fierce gusts swept barely clear of his face.

Pip!

His skin split under the pressure, sending a sharp sting through him. That was nothing. If it was the price of dodging the attacks, he'd gotten off absurdly cheap.

I'll pay them back with interest.

His body moved before the thought was complete. Straightening, he released the spear shaft and thrust out both palms.

Whoom—BOOM!

A shockwave and crash shook the ground.

But the sword and claws, shrouded in immense magical power, canceled out the force of his Flame Divine Palm. They didn't stop there.

Shraaah!

The Death Knight Legion Commander brought its sword down like a streak of light.

—Grrraaaah!

The Lycanthrope charged with a roar. Beside it, the Manticore Lord lashed its iron-hard, spike-covered tail like a whip.

They're working together? Monsters from different species?

Jin Taekyung's eyes widened at the attacks converging from three directions. That brief hesitation left the slightest opening.

Fwoooosh! BOOM!

Three S-rank monsters. Together, they struck with more destructive force than he could withstand even with his Scorching Yang Qi pushed to its limit.

And the Manticore Lord was even stronger and more cunning than he'd expected.

Whoosh. Slice!

Hot. As if someone had seared his thigh with fire.

Before he could fully feel the pain, three more flashes burst into view one after another.

BOOM!

A crash like the sky splitting open sent him flying backward.

Jin Taekyung twisted in midair, regained his balance, and threw a punch the instant he landed.

Poom!

Heat erupted from his fist. The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist swept forward, setting monsters ablaze. As they shrieked and burned, dark crimson magical power surged from among them.

Whoooosh.

Pressure bore down from every direction, snuffing out the flames in an instant.

The three S-rank monsters had cut down even their writhing subordinates without hesitation. They were about to charge Jin Taekyung again when a voice suddenly rang out.

“Good. That’s far enough.”

At the unmistakable sound of the Demon Realm language, they stopped in their tracks.

The Skeleton King grinned at them, then tossed a remark at Jin Taekyung.

“Madman.”

Jin Taekyung met his unfriendly look with a calm question.

“Why?”

“What am I supposed to do when you charge off alone like that? Weren’t we just saying we’d each take one?”

“I was testing them. Seeing which was strongest and which was weakest.”

The Skeleton King’s gaze dropped to Jin Taekyung’s thigh. It looked as though something had torn a chunk out of it, and blood covered the wound.

The Manticore Lord had struck there with the Fire Dragon Armor around Jin Taekyung’s upper body in mind. It was as clever as it was strong.

“Looks more like it tested your blood.”

“They’re stronger than I expected. One of them, especially, is practically a named monster even among the S-ranks.”

“Which one?”

“The one in the middle.”

“The Manticore? It does stand out, even at a glance.”

The Skeleton King glared at the Manticore Lord, his face hardening. His voice turned cold.

“So that’s the one that wounded you.”

“It’s not that bad. I’d be much better off taking the Manticore—”

“Fine. I’ll take the Death Knight.”

“…?”

“What’s with that unpleasant look?”

“No, I just thought this was where you’d say you were going to avenge your friend or something.”

The Skeleton King’s eyes widened.

“What the hell are you talking about? We’ve got a much better chance if the strongest fight the strongest.”

“…”

“Anyway, it’s settled. You take the Manticore. I’ll take the Death Knight. And that Lycanthrope over there…”

He trailed off, looked around, and blinked.

“Why is it just the two of us?”

Jin Taekyung, who had staunched the bleeding in his thigh, kindly explained.

“One bastard already ran off.”

“Huh?”

“Maybe he had a shred of conscience left, because he didn’t run away entirely. He’s back there in the front ranks.”

Far away, Yamamoto Genji had sidled up beside Choi Minwoo and put on a determined expression. The Skeleton King spotted him and muttered, “I’m going to kill that bastard.”

“Sure. But first, let’s finish this damn fight as quickly as we can.”

Jin Taekyung spat out bloody phlegm and lowered his spear.

Behind him, flying monsters were already shrieking amid bursts of explosions.

Magic Johnson can hold them off.

He could only trust him, just as Johnson and the others had trusted him.

Step. Thud.

The three S-rank monsters stepped forward, and the entire army moved with them.

No matter how many they killed, the wave of monsters never seemed to shrink. And the open desert all around them was the worst possible battlefield for humans.

“You know what I regret most since I became a monster?” the Skeleton King asked.

Jin Taekyung answered without hesitation. “Not getting to go clubbing.”

“Wrong. Getting mixed up with you.”

“Really? I’m the exact opposite.”

“What?”

“One of the best things I’ve ever done was get you out of that Gate.”

“…Damn it. Am I the only piece of trash here?”

“You already know. Why ask?”

The Skeleton King let out a quiet laugh and took a deep breath. Deathly energy flowed out instead of breath, raising the monsters strewn around them.

One thousand in all.

That was the most he could maintain while fighting and commanding them at the same time. Against the vast army drawing nearer and steadily gaining speed, it was a meager force.

“Can we… hold them all back?”

No.

Jin Taekyung swallowed the answer on the tip of his tongue.

Someone is going to die. No matter what.

That was battle. That was war. There was no way to save everyone.

He couldn’t promise they would all make it out alive. He could promise one thing: revenge.

“No matter how many of us die here today…”

Shing.

As his words trailed off, he leveled his gleaming spearhead at the monsters.

“Every last one of them dies by my hand.”

The Skeleton King’s eyes widened.

KRUNCH!

A wave of monsters beyond counting crashed over them.

…!

…!!

My ears rang. The movement of more than ten thousand monsters shook the ground, and their cries seemed to reach the ends of the earth and the sky above.

At the head of that army, right at its center, were the three of them.

Fwoosh. Slice!

Fire Dragon’s Single Tail.

A line of flame traced along the spearhead and cut through the air. Dozens of heads caught in its path, unable to dodge or block, rolled across the ground.

Splatter!

Blood sprayed a moment later. But the monsters that should have charged us with savage cries scattered instead, avoiding me and the Skeleton King.

Was it because of the martial prowess I’d shown? My Intimidation?

No. The monsters avoiding me to charge the Hunters weren’t afraid. They were obeying someone else.

The kind of obedience you saw only in trained elite troops.

“You’ve got to be fucking kidding me…!”

Crunch!

The Skeleton King blew apart an ogre’s head and shouted in anger.

Even with his undead army, the two of us couldn’t block every enemy’s path.

For every ten we killed, a hundred got through. For every hundred, a thousand monsters slipped past.

Our net was tightly woven, but far too small. And that was exactly what they intended.

“So it’s you. The human that person spoke of.”

The voice seemed to come from inside my head. Smooth and composed, like a nobleman’s, its tone betrayed a keen intelligence. Its words confirmed my suspicion.

“The Prophet. Where is he now?”

A mythical monster with the face and body of a tiger, the tusks of a boar, and the horns of a bull.

The Manticore Lord smiled.

“He is everywhere, and nowhere.”

“What the hell does that mean?” the Skeleton King asked.

“It means he’ll tell us if we beat the shit out of him.”

I brought my spearhead down toward the monster.

No—toward *them*.

Shwoosh!

The wind split apart.

Chapter 806

There's an old saying that's been passed down in the Murim for ages.

A Third Rate swordsman gets beaten to death by street thugs. A Peak master dies fighting a master like himself. But the only things that can kill a Supreme Peak master are his own arrogance and carelessness.

That was how martial artists saw Supreme Peak masters.

Beings to be marveled at and feared.

While everyone else wandered Murim's treacherous mountains, they stood on the highest peaks and looked down on them all.

But there was no such thing as *invincible* in this world.

Even among those who reach the chosen realm, there are clear differences in strength.

People looking up from below couldn't tell. Those who stood on peaks of their own could see and feel someone else beyond the thick fog—standing higher or lower than they were.

I was no different.

Shwaa!

A sharp gust burst from the spearhead as I slashed down at an angle.

It tore apart the limbs of monsters unlucky enough to cross its path and shot toward its target, only to die away amid a tremendous roar.

—Kyaaaaa!

The shockwave imbued with magical power faded along with the wind.

I stared at the monster that had canceled out my spear strike with a single roar.

Strong.

Magical power boiled all around me, prickling my skin. The air tasted bitter and stale with every breath.

Manticore Lord.

A monster straight out of myth. A leader strong enough to be called a *Lord* even among its own kind.

Step.

The moment its lion-like forepaw touched the blood-soaked sand, it vanished from where it stood and tore through space.

Boom!

As fast as the wind. Faster, even.

In some ways, it was far more troublesome than Leviathan, the last named monster I'd taken down.

Leviathan had possessed far more magical power. But the strength I'd felt from this thing earlier, together with the speed it was showing now and the size of its body, made it better suited to one-on-one combat than mass slaughter.

And there's the Lycanthrope Champion, too.

I couldn't afford to let my guard down.

I watched the two S-rank monsters and kicked off the ground at just the right moment, sending a Sound Transmission to the Skeleton King.

—Don't lose and embarrass yourself.

No answer came.

The Death Knight Legion Commander had summoned a Nightmare—a ghost horse that was an A-rank monster in its own right—and was leaping high into the air to come crashing down on the Skeleton King.

BOOM!

A thunderous crash erupted behind me, already far off in the distance. The Skeleton King's voice rang across the battlefield.

"A mere legion commander dares challenge me? Kneel before your king!"

It would have been ideal if the Death Knight Legion Commander had knelt and sworn allegiance. But reality wasn't so accommodating.

They already served another master, and right now a tail and claws brimming with magical power were bearing down on me.

BANG!

The spearhead of White Flame shuddered as I held it upright to block the attack.

But unlike our earlier clash, this time *they* were the ones who had to back off.

Whoosh! Slice!

I brought the spearhead down without hesitation. It sliced through the half-man, half-beast Lycanthrope Champion's huge, hook-like claw as easily as tofu.

Not a difficult opponent.

If it were the only one.

—Grr?

The Lycanthrope Champion let out a startled growl and stumbled backward. I was about to cut it in two when the Manticore Lord's tail—knocked aside by my spear—writhed like a snake and lunged for my face.

Whoom!

The wind pressure brushing past my neck felt as heavy as a block of iron.

But I'd already seen that move once.

If I'd been facing all three of them alone, I would have been in real trouble. Now, things were different.

One at a time.

Fwoosh.

The Lycanthrope Champion saw the flames gathering in my hand and twisted away, but it was half a beat too late.

No. I was faster.

BOOM!

The Flame Divine Palm struck it dead-on and sent it sliding backward. It clutched its blackened arm and let out a roar that sounded almost like a scream.

—GRAAAAAH!

Too bad.

It was the weakest of the three, but an S-rank monster was still an S-rank monster. My strike had missed its intended target—its chest—by a hair.

One strike. One more will finish it.

But the Manticore Lord was every bit as cunning as it was strong.

Just as I moved to swing my spear and finish off the Lycanthrope, it came for my back faster than it had moved at any point so far.

BOOM!

I blocked the claw that crashed down like lightning.

The spear shaft shook under the tremendous pressure, and my legs—usually free to move even in the desert—sank deep into the sand.

That, too, was part of its plan.

Shwaa! Thud!

Its tail slammed into my side with more weight and force than a battering ram.

The stinger on its tip couldn't pierce all the way through my Fire Dragon Armor, but I had to bear the full force of the tremendous impact it delivered.

"Ugh…!"

My vision went hazy. Something hot surged up through my chest.

I swallowed the blood rising in my throat and reached out through the blur.

Open Inventory. Summon.

As one hand left the spear shaft, the pressure on it grew heavier. I drew a dagger from my Inventory and swung it in a flash.

Shhk, slice!

There was only one sound of cutting, but three thin lines appeared across the iron-hard tail.

The Manticore Lord's eyes widened as it tried to crush me beneath its two massive forepaws.

FWOOSH!

Blood belatedly sprayed from the faint lines like a fountain.

Its jaws gaped wide in pain, releasing the stench of countless deaths.

—GRAAAAAAAH!

The lion-like roar it unleashed right in my face left my ears ringing.

No. My eardrums had to have burst.

You son of a bitch.

I clenched my teeth, feeling hot blood run from my ears.

As the force bearing down on me briefly eased, I drove the dagger still in my hand into its ribs.

Thud!

The Force on the dagger came from Scorching Yang Qi.

Its lava-like heat cut through tough hide and flesh, broke bone, and burned through what lay inside.

Sssss!

—GRAAAAH!

—Kyaaaaa!

The Manticore Lord's cry seemed to come twice, the sounds overlapping like audio from broken earbuds. Maybe it was because my eardrums had burst.

But my instincts told me I wasn't imagining it.

This…

They were different cries. I hadn't misheard.

The first was a scream of pain. The second was a roar of rage.

And my bad feelings were never wrong.

Lycanthrope Champion.

As its name came to mind, the half-man, half-beast monster I'd briefly forgotten lunged at me from behind.

Shwaa!

Its speed was dazzling—every bit worthy of an S-rank monster.

One arm swung at its side as though it might crumble to ash at any moment. The other was still sound, and when it swept that arm toward me, its hooked claws flashed.

Too late to pull out the dagger and swing it.

Countless movements and possible futures flashed through my mind in that instant.

In the end, only one choice remained.

As the world seemed to slow around me, I let go of the dagger lodged in the Manticore Lord's ribs and thrust out my palm.

Fwoosh—crack!

The internal energy I'd hurriedly drawn up scattered. Flames burst apart.

Dizzying pain shot through my hand. I stared at the silver claw that had pierced my palm and emerged from the back of it.

...Fuck.

It had stopped just short of my face. I couldn't help swearing.

But that wasn't the end of the pain waiting for me.

Crack. Crunch!

Bones shifted, and a neck stretched out like a turtle's.

With my life hanging in the balance, the Manticore Lord finally used the ability it had cunningly kept hidden. Its neck shot over the spear shaft between us, bringing its jaws straight at me.

—GRAAH!

Its mouth gaped all the way to its ears like a ghost from a horror story, reeking of rotting corpses. At the sight of its huge, saw-toothed teeth, every hair on my body seemed to stand on end.

"...!"

A chill ran down my spine.

If those jaws closed on me, I was dead.

I twisted with all my strength. The teeth that had been about to swallow my head whole brushed my hair and sank into my collarbone.

Or rather, into the red armor covering it.

CRUNCH!

Beep. Beep-beep!

SYSTEM

Part of your Fire Dragon Armor has been damaged!
The durability of your Fire Dragon Armor has dropped significantly!
Danger! Danger! If you are exposed to another attack like that, your Fire Dragon Armor may be automatically returned to your Inventory!
Manticore Lord's Venom has entered through a gap in the damaged armor!
Status abnormality Poisoned has been applied!
Detoxify as soon as possible! If you do not detoxify within the time limit, your condition may worsen!

Damn it. What the hell is this now?

I'd thought my collarbone felt a little prickly. Now, out of nowhere, it was venom?

All I'd been born with was a pair of balls. This bastard was named-monster level, and it had more damn abilities than I could count.

"...Human!"

Even in the middle of his own fight, the Skeleton King had somehow seen what happened. His urgent shout came from far behind me.

But despite his worry, I had no intention of dying here. Not even the slightest.

If anything, I was almost glad that being **Poisoned** had dulled my senses.

At least now I wouldn't feel much pain from what I was about to do.

"Thanks for the help, you son of a bitch."

At my barely audible whisper, the Manticore Lord's eyes widened.

I dropped White Flame from my free hand and slammed that hand into what I guessed was its throat.

Thwack!

A heavy blow.

The Manticore Lord caught its breath, malice filling its eyes.

Thud!

Its teeth drove in harder than before, prying open the gap in my Fire Dragon Armor and sinking deep into my collarbone.

Beep. Beep-beep. The warnings rang in my ears, but the pain had faded even further. I could move my hand without a care, though its palm was little more than raw flesh caught on a hook.

Crack.

The Lycanthrope Champion's claw was still lodged through my palm. It bared its teeth at me in a sneer.

Pure contempt.

The sneer lasted only an instant.

—Grr?

Its face filled with surprise. No matter how hard it strained, it couldn't make me budge. As it blinked at me, I spoke calmly.

"You think I can't beat *you*, you little shit, just because I'm in bad shape?"

On Strength stats alone, I had seniority over an ogre's dad.

Even with all my stats drastically reduced by the special debuff, my physical abilities were still comparable to—or better than—those of most S-rank monsters.

And the Lycanthrope Champion was built for Agility, not Strength. I could slam it into the ground with one hand.

"Now, you little punk… Attention!"

Whack! Crunch!

I kicked its knee joint, shattering it in an instant.

As the strongest of the half-man, half-beast warriors let out a mournful cry, I kept a firm grip on its claw and slammed the monster into the ground.

Whoom—BANG!

The impact raised a cloud of dust. At the same time, blood spurted from my palm as the claw tore free.

But only one thing mattered.

At last, I had a free hand.

Open Inventory. Summon.

A sharp dagger flashed. Above it, blazing hellfire surged and flew toward the Manticore Lord's head.

—…!

The Lycanthrope Champion realized my plan and threw itself forward.

Too late.

Thud—KRAAAAAAASH!

The blade cut through hide and shattered flesh and bone. Flames exploded.

Ding.

Just as the clear chime I'd been waiting for rang in my ears, a flash of light suddenly swept in from somewhere and cut through the Lycanthrope Champion's neck as it charged at me.

Slice!

"I'm here, Jin Sama[3222]!"

"…"

This son of a bitch stole my kill.

[3222] *Sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

Chapter 807

Even a Supreme Peak master will go down if he gets kicked in the balls. No matter how strange or powerful a monster is, its weaknesses are much like a human's.

Blow its head off, or burst its heart.

Of course, there are exceptions to everything.

Some Trolls can put even a shattered head back together. Golems won't fall until you destroy the core hidden somewhere inside them.

A Lich, both undead and a skilled black wizard, might store part of its soul in a Life Force Vessel.

But as far as I knew, there wasn't a Lycanthrope anywhere that could survive having its head cut off.

Not even an S-rank monster that had earned the title of Champion as the strongest warrior of its kind.

"I'm here, Jin Sama[3223]!"

"..."

I looked back and forth between Yamamoto Genji, who was chattering so loudly he was spitting, and the headless body of the EXP... No, the Lycanthrope Champion.

No, fuck...

What kind of bullshit was this?

It had been the perfect time to level up. The meal was already laid out in front of me, and some bastard had swooped in and gobbled it all up.

I was so furious my hands and feet felt ready to shake.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Status abnormality Convulsions has been applied!
Status abnormality Poisoned is worsening!
Manticore Lord's Venom must be removed from your body as soon as possible!

"..."

Right. No wonder my hands were shaking so much.

I was already in bad shape, and the anger made my vision blur for a moment.

If things had gone as I'd calculated, I'd have leveled up by now and recovered completely. Since that hadn't happened, I had no choice but to use another method.

[3223] *Sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing respect, stronger than *san*.

“Uh? Jin Sama[3224], is something wrong?”

“Do I look like I’m all right, you fucking idiot?”

“Ah. Oh…”

That shut Yamamoto Genji up. I gave the command in my head.

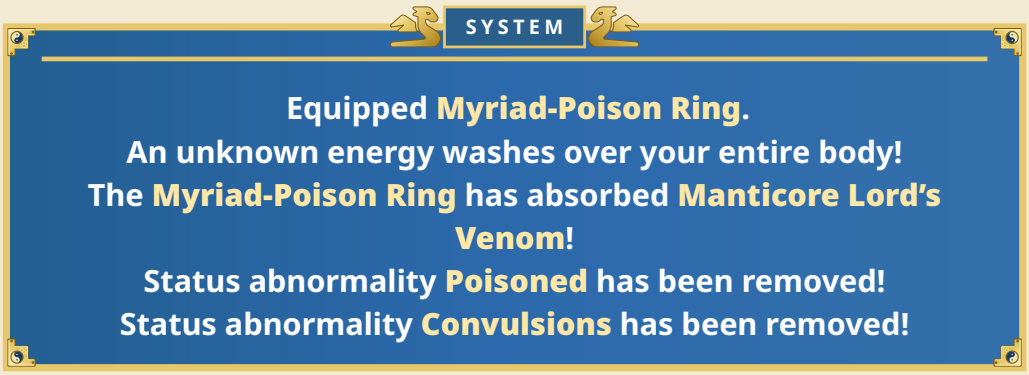
Open Inventory. Summon.

The System manifested in response to the command.

Shk.

The moment my trembling fingers touched something cold, a clear chime rang out, different from the earlier ones.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



As the chimes rang one after another, my vision cleared and the convulsions stopped.

The Myriad-Poison Ring had drawn in the poison spreading from my collarbone through the rest of my body. It gleamed with its familiar black light.

I didn’t level up, but thank God I had the Myriad-Poison Ring.

It was a good thing I’d ended the fight quickly. The venom the Manticore Lord had carried was truly terrifying.

With Scorching Yang Qi, which was the natural enemy of poison, and a top-grade potion, I could have been cured without much difficulty. But a potion ultimately worked by paying in advance with the body’s energy and vitality to maximize its recovery.

With so many enemies still out there, a risk-free level-up would have been a hundred times better.

Of course…

“A-are you all right?”

Some bastard had been hanging back, watching for an opening, then rushed in and stole the last hit from me.

“Forget it. Don’t worry about it.”

But what could I do?

[3224] *Sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing respect, stronger than *san*.

The bus had already left, and I didn't have time to stand at an empty bus stop waiting for the next one and slap Yamamoto Genji across the face.

The one bit of good news amid all the bad was that the Skeleton King was the kind of excellent monster who knew how to finish his assigned job on time.

Crack-crunch!

We'd gotten quite far apart while fighting our respective opponents, but I could clearly see—and hear—the Death Knight, well over two meters[3225] tall, crumple along with his armor.

I heard its final scream, too.

—GRAAAAAAH!

Fwoosh!

That was the end.

Black mist flowed out from beneath the helmet pulled low over its face. The Skeleton King absorbed the Death Knight's soul as it escaped just before Erasure, as though sucking it in. Then he grinned at me as I approached using qinggong[3226].

"You monster."

He spotted Yamamoto Genji tucked under my arm like a piece of luggage and added, "That fucking bastard."

I agreed. If that little shit had held up the Lycanthrope Champion for even a moment, everything would've ended much more smoothly.

But kicking Yamamoto Genji in the joints in the middle of a battle involving thousands—tens of thousands—of fighters would be something only a lunatic would do. If I had time for that, I needed to use it to save one more person.

"Let's go."

With that brief word, I shot forward. My limbs creaked, proof of the fierce battle that had just taken place, and my internal energy was considerably depleted.

Even so, I had to go. I had to fight.

Shweee—BOOM!

The spearhead of White Flame, sent flying with tremendous force, swept through the rear of the monster army swarming like ants.

A muffled boom swallowed their screams, and flames burst out, burning the living monsters' limbs.

One more.

I kept running without slowing down.

I pulled another spear from my Inventory, gripped it in a reverse hold, and hurled it.

Boom!

[3225] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

[3226] *Qinggong* is a martial-arts lightness skill associated with swift movement and leaps.

A thunderous crack split the desert.

The spear didn’t carry as much internal energy as the first, but the sheer force and speed behind its spearhead were enough to pierce dozens of monsters.

Crack-crunch!

—GRAAAH!

Even a glancing blow burst heads like watermelons and sent severed limbs flying.

The monster army, which had seemed as though it would never shrink no matter how many I killed, began to falter.

Boom!

—Grrk, gaaah!

The screams drew closer by the moment. The stench grew stronger.

By the time I hurled a third spear, hundreds had already fallen. I kicked off the air and soared upward, flung Yamamoto Genji from under my arm toward the ground, and reached out.

Come.

Shweee! Snap!

White Flame answered my call through the Middle Dantian and flew into my hand.

Its grip had become so familiar that I could recognize it without looking.

As soon as I reclaimed it, I poured in Scorching Yang Qi. The transparent spearhead took on a reddish glow.

Fwoosh.

Flames. Wind. A world moving slowly.

And… the eyes staring blankly at me as I soared through the air, with the entire battlefield laid out below.

Whoosh.

The wind brushed across my body. Time, which had stopped, gradually returned to its usual pace.

I saw opposite emotions appear in countless wide eyes.

There was joy in some. In others, despair was slowly sinking into reality.

Humans and monsters. Monsters and humans.

No one there needed to be told which side felt which.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear. This form.

I drew in a breath.

My body descended slowly, keeping pace with time as I perceived it, while the flame-filled spearhead rose high, as if to pierce the sky.

Fwoosh.

At that moment, when the space around me warped under the extreme heat, a massive shadow that had been circling over the Hunters surrounded by monsters shot toward me.

—Screee!

A piercing cry rang in my ears.

I didn't have to look to sense its approach. Unlike the other monsters, it flew toward me like a streak of light. The gale raised by a single flap of its wings carried immense magical power.

The leader of the Griffins.

Yeah. It had to be.

As a flying monster that ranged through the sky as if it owned it, it was one of the most troublesome opponents in its own way.

But…

It doesn't matter.

Ignoring the Griffins rushing at me with a gale of magical power, I brought the spearhead down.

Heavenly Strike.

Whoooooom!

Flames poured over the spearhead of White Flame, wiping out the gale of magical power rushing toward me and cleaving through space.

A fierce, razor-sharp slash like a dragon's claw descended on the center of the tightly packed monster army.

Fwoosh!

The heat and flash were so intense they seemed capable of melting everything before they even touched it.

Hellfire engulfed hundreds—perhaps a thousand—monsters and exploded.

BOOM! Rumble-rumble!

A rain of fire poured down. Screams and death flowed like lava.

Neither the hides of the upper-level monsters—unmarked even by bullets—nor the quick-footed lower-level ones who sensed danger and tried to flee could escape it.

Death was equal for all the monsters, and the leader of the Griffins watching the scene let out a roar like a scream.

—Kyaaaah!

Whoom. A heavy pressure pushed against my whole body.

I raised my head. The leader of the Griffins, already overhead, was shooting toward me.

Even within its massive shadow, which blocked the sunlight, the monster's beak shone like the sun, packed with immense magical power.

If I met that attack head-on?

Even I wouldn't come away unscathed.

At the fork in the road I'd faced a moment ago, I'd chosen not to fight it, but to break up the monster army's formation.

But—

"I don't have to be the one to do it. Right?"

—…!

At the Demon Realm language carried through the System, the flying beast's pupils narrowed into vertical slits.

A moment's hesitation at the very end.

And those who had been waiting for that moment didn't let me down.

Shwoop! Clang!

The Griffin leader knocked aside something that flew up from the ground with a sharp crack, then staggered under the force of the blow.

That's…

A spear made of bone.

As it fell to the ground, its job done, I thought of one person—or rather, one monster.

The Skeleton King.

That bastard never got tired, yet he was so much slower than me. He'd finally made it here.

But the person I'd really been counting on was someone else.

Rumble.

The air all around us shuddered. Everyone here, not just me, felt the battlefield's atmosphere grow heavy.

I felt the wind die down in an instant, and the enormous mana rising from somewhere deep below press down on the battlefield.

—Screep?

The leader and around a hundred Griffins looked at one another in confusion.

They were no longer beating their wings.

No. Someone had bound them in midair.

"Rise, then crash back down."

The voice that followed held none of its usual cheer. It was bleak and subdued.

"Reverse Gravity."

And then—

Whoooooom!

Gravity within the area went wild.

Mana seized the remaining flying monsters with measured precision and slammed them into the ground.

—Screee!

As I listened to the Griffin leader cry out, a thought struck me.

What did you call the sight of around a hundred massive Griffins plummeting from hundreds of meters[3227] up like streaks of light?

A spectacular view? Or…

Magic?

At least one thing was certain.

The Grand Mage who'd staged this incredible end to the battle deserved to be called the world's greatest War Mage.

Rumble! Crack-crunch!

The flames spread without end. Chaos took hold. Countless monsters were crushed beneath the Griffins' huge bodies as they rained down like a meteor shower.

I looked over the monster army, its center utterly broken, and shouted with internal energy behind my voice.

"Formation! Change!"

This battle was already won.

"Kill every last one of those bastards!"

A mighty roar shook heaven and earth. A thousand spears and blades, still sharp, surged forward like a wave.

[3227] One hundred meters is about 328 ft; hundreds of meters means hundreds to thousands of feet.

Chapter 808

The Great Cataclysm was a massive event that changed the course of human history.

Naturally, it became the subject of countless studies and analyses. Scholars around the world identified three decisive reasons humanity had won.

First: the existence of Cheon Taemin.

Second, the emergence of the Awakened, who would come to be known as Hunters.

And third:

Human intelligence and will.

They were right.

If Cheon Taemin's existence and the emergence of the Awakened had been unexpected salvation, human intelligence and will were what allowed us to overcome any crisis.

They were the reason humanity had won—and the monsters had lost.

Decades ago.

And… at this very moment.

CRRRRACK!

With a tremendous roar, a thousand Hunters surged forward like a wave.

The healers' blessings rained down on the tanks, who had exhausted every ounce of strength holding back the monsters pouring in from all sides. The towering Grand Mage dispelled the defensive magic that had enveloped the area and revealed his true power.

"Burn as much as you like. Cut straight through."

Mana surged at his boiling command.

A spell on this scale would have taken an ordinary mage several minutes to prepare. Yet Magic Johnson swept his staff through the air, and the Magic Formation that appeared above him activated after only a short incantation.

"Fire Wall."

Fwoosh—WHOOOOSH!

Flames carrying terrible heat raced in every direction. They burned through thick scales, melted flesh and bone, and split the monster army's ranks down the middle.

—Kyaaaaaah!

Cries of pain rang out as an acrid stench rose all around us.

The wide-area spell had torn straight through their packed formation. Amid the chaos, a higher-level monster that seemed fairly intelligent hurried to pull the broken ranks back together.

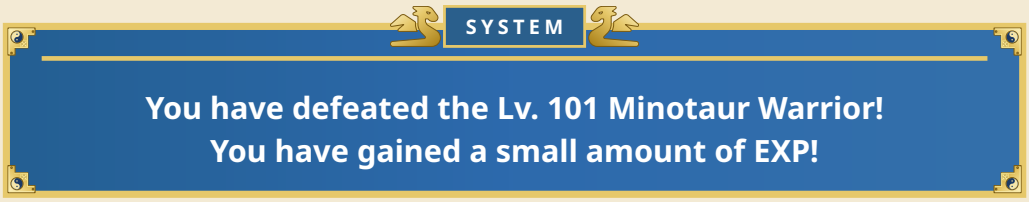
Or tried to.

—Alu. Karsh…!

CRUNCH!

I dropped onto it from above and burst its hard skull with a punch packed with internal energy.

Ding.



Stagger. Thud.

With the System notification, its stumbling body fell like a rotten log.

I spat a wad of phlegm onto the corpse, adjusted my grip on White Flame, and muttered, “You piece of shit. Way to ruin the moment.”

The monsters around me blinked at the sight of me dropping out of the sky like a comet. They had the innocent eyes of herbivores gathered by a stream.

But I knew better.

Those eyes looked gentle only because the creatures behind them were so stupid. The instincts hidden beneath that look were more savage and cruel than those of any other living thing.

—Grrk?

“Nice meeting you. Goodbye.”

With that first and last greeting, I spun and swung my spearhead.

CRRRACK!

Bone separated from flesh, and a haze of blood filled the air. Dozens fell to the first strike. I stepped forward and swung again, clearing the space around me.

Squish.

As I approached, stepping through the blood-soaked sand, the air around me gave a sharp, tingling hum.

Scorching Yang Qi stirred up intense heat, but the monsters’ eyes had gone cold long ago.

One Against a Thousand.

My overwhelming martial prowess and aura radiated outward. **Intimidation**, so palpable I could almost reach out and touch it, tightened around their bodies. Fear wiped away their ferocity and swallowed their instincts.

The Hunters had waited patiently for this moment. They didn’t miss it.

CRUNCH!

“Charge! Wipe them all out!”

“Die, you bastards!”

Clang-clang! Slice!

With a tremendous roar, a shining wave of steel crashed into the monsters.

The battle had been relatively short, but these elites had held their ground against a force more than ten times their size without taking heavy losses.

After holding back for so long against the endless tide, the Hunters seized their chance. They drove into the ranks Magic Johnson’s spell had broken apart, stabbing and slashing at every monster in their path.

Slice, thud-thud-thud!

“God damn it! Motherfucker!”

—GRAAAAAH!

Curses and screams mingled as aura and magical power, light and darkness, clashed all around us.

And with every passing second, the balance tipped further toward the light.

“Team Three, watch two o’clock! Circle around and break through!”

“Ranged unit, ready! Fire!”

“Fire!”

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh—BOOM!

Arrows whistled through the air in a sudden rain. The mages’ wide-area spells swept across the battlefield.

Each team moved like a living organism, their tactics disciplined and aimed at the enemy’s openings.

The monster army had grown stronger than before as the concentration of magical power rose. But if the superior bodies and magical power they were born with were enough to win every battle, the monsters would have conquered the world already.

“Come on, you bastards.”

My voice came out cold as I shot forward. The moment I chose a target, I was already closing the distance and moving on to my next attack.

Slice, boom!

I cut the throat of a goblin shaman preparing a spell, then smashed the chest of the Orc chieftain beside it.

The Orcs lost their leader in an instant. As they milled about in confusion, a rain of arrows fell on their heads.

Whoosh, thud-thud-thud!

Aura-coated arrowheads pierced their thick hides and passed through their heads and chests.

A particularly huge Troll hurried to retreat as I approached. Just then, two streaks of light curved out from behind it.

Thud, slice!

The first sword pierced its chest. The second cut off its head.

The movements were coordinated, without a hint of hesitation or wasted effort.

The swordsmen chopped the Troll, still twitching despite its fatal wounds, into dozens of pieces. Then they spotted me and smiled faintly.

Xiao Shen. And Team Leader Choi.

There was no need to exchange words amid the chaos of battle. Not when we understood each other without speaking.

They gave me a light nod, then charged toward another target. They were going after the higher-level monsters intelligent enough to control their respective groups.

Good choice.

Most people instinctively resist killing living things, especially other people.

I didn't know whether that reluctance was an instinct ingrained over our long history or something we'd learned as civilized beings. Either way, it was real.

Monsters were different from the start. Born to struggle, they barely had a concept of their own kind.

Take out the monsters giving orders to each group, and that's when the real chaos begins.

No. The chaos had already begun.

Four S-rank monsters, including the strongest of them, the Manticore Lord, had fallen. On my orders, Magic Johnson and the Hunters had stopped concentrating solely on defense. Now they were driving into the heart of the monster army and grinding it down.

The leaders of each group—lower-ranking commanders, in effect—were falling across the battlefield to A-rank Hunters led by Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen. Yamamoto Genji was making his own conspicuous contribution.

"Hup. Gale Slash!"

The name of the technique, barked in a low voice, was pure Japanese bravado. But the power behind that single sword strike was no bluff.

Shwaa—slice!

A flash streaked across the battlefield, and dozens of monsters fell, spraying blood.

Hunters rushed into the space he'd opened and cut down every monster in their path.

CRUNCH! FWOOSH!

The formation slowly collapsed. The front line gave ground.

But waiting for the monster army as it gave ground, step by step, were the Skeleton King and a thousand Skeletons, blocking off their rear.

"Surround them! If you've got no teeth, hold them with your bones!"

Clack-clack-clack!

—GRAAAAH!

CRUNCH!

A massive monster several meters tall[3228] swung its mace, smashing a dozen Skeletons to pieces.

At the same time, dozens more latched onto it or climbed its body, driving rusty swords and teeth into its enormous frame.

Thud. Crack!

—GRAAAAAH!

Its furious roar became a scream of pain. When the massive monster finally met a gruesome death, a cold blue light appeared in its eyes.

—Grr. Ah. Ah. Ah.

Reborn as an undead, the massive monster charged off, dragging its heavy body along.

The Hunters flinched at the sight. Then they spotted the Skeleton King and went right back to fighting as if nothing had happened.

“Hit them! They’re breaking!”

“Their formation’s falling apart! Don’t back down—keep pushing!”

Less than an hour had passed.

But victory was already tipping toward the humans.

Thousands of monsters had already been wiped out. The force that had initially outnumbered us ten to one was now down to five to one—and the gap was shrinking by the second.

CRACK! THUD!

An Ogre Warrior more than four meters tall[3229] collapsed without a scream.

Its chest blown open, it pitched forward. I planted a foot on its shoulder and leaped into the air, taking in the battlefield below during that brief instant.

It’s over. Push a little longer, and we win.

There was no trace of the momentum the monsters had shown at the start, when they’d surrounded the Hunters and attacked without letup.

They’d lost four S-rank monsters and the lesser leaders commanding their groups. Now they were in utter disarray. The Grand Mage’s wide-area spells from the front and the Skeleton King’s undead soldiers pressing them from behind only deepened the confusion.

And the Hunters are fighting like hell.

The monster army was nothing but a mass of beasts now. Victory was only a matter of time.

[3228] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

[3229] Four meters is about 13 ft.

Not one of those countless monsters could stop us. Could stop me.

Except for the one being that still hadn't shown itself.

Where the hell are you?

Thinking of The Prophet, a mystery from beginning to end, I dropped toward the ground.

BOOM! Slice!

White Flame's spearhead plunged down with me and split open another monster's skull. Its body split cleanly in two and fell to either side. Between the halves, I saw eyes filled with fear.

"Die."

I charged like a beast of prey and rampaged like a predator.

The lower-level monsters froze as though gripped by **Fear**, staring at the death bearing down on them. The higher-level monsters fought back with the last of their strength.

They fell in different ways, but the result was the same.

Death.

Thud!

I twisted the spearhead lodged between a Lycanthrope's eyes and pulled it free. Brain matter ran down White Flame's transparent blade.

A tingling ache rose through my arms and legs. They hadn't stopped moving.

Damn it.

How long had I been fighting? How many monsters had I killed?

I didn't know. Better not to. The moment my brain registered it, my body would feel even more exhausted.

And if The Prophet was watching me now, all the more reason not to show him any weakness.

Hoo. Hah.

I steadied my breathing and adjusted my grip on White Flame.

As I turned to face the next monsters, I realized the balance of the battle had finally tipped all the way over.

Rumble. Rrrumble!

—GRAAAAAH!

—Krrk. GRAAAAH!

The desert shook. With terrified cries, wave after wave of monsters were retreating.

They're running. All those monsters.

The thought that flashed through my mind was exactly what I was seeing.

Their advantage in numbers?

The monster army had lost its will to fight and was fleeing at full speed. None of them cared about that anymore.

The Hunters stared, blinking, then raised their tired spears and swords. With bloodshot eyes, they raced after the monsters.

“Kill every last one!”

The only thing left on the battlefield was slaughter.

Chapter 809

It was like watching a massive dam collapse.

Boom. Boom. KABOOM!

The most ferocious of the large monsters turned and fled.

Every time their several-meter-tall bodies[3230] took a step, the enormous weight crushed corpses and smaller monsters underfoot like tofu.

Crunch! Crack-crunch!

—Kiiiiie!

—Kyargh!

Painful death cries rang out all around us, but not one of them belonged to a Hunter. At least on this battlefield today, the weak weren't human. They were monsters.

The strong devour the weak.

Monsters followed the instincts stamped into them from birth. But this wasn't the ferocity that had driven them to destroy cities and slaughter humans. What drove them now was something more primal.

Fear.

The S-rank monsters—so powerful the others hadn't dared meet their eyes—were dead. So were most of the leaders who'd commanded the groups behind them.

Their threadbare chain of command had collapsed, and the ten-to-one gap in numbers was closing fast.

Several thousand monsters remained, by a rough count. But a beast that had lost the will to fight was easier prey than a herbivore.

And after the grueling battle they'd fought, the Hunters had no intention of ending the hunt just yet.

"They're running! Wipe them out!"

"Don't let a single one get away!"

"Aaaah!"

Bloodshot eyes. Weapons slick with flesh and blood.

Soaked from head to toe, the Hunters looked like people made of blood as they chased their prey. They bound slipping sword hilts tight with leather straps. Arms trembling from drawing bowstrings again and again reached for quivers at their sides.

They were exhausted. They wanted to collapse on the sticky sand and sleep.

But they couldn't stop.

"Because of you bastards, Benjamin—Benjamin… You motherfuckers!"

[3230] A meter is about 3.28 ft.

Some had lost friends.

“N-no! Emma!”

Some had lost a comrade who was also a lover.

“Motherfucker. Were you in San Francisco a month ago, too? What? Damn it. Quit spewing shit I can’t understand and go to hell.”

Others had a recent wrong to avenge.

They had to kill monsters, again and again, until their anger was spent.

Shhk. Thud!

Monstrous cries rang out as green blood sprayed in every direction. An arrow flew in from somewhere, pierced an Orc’s head, and drove through a Troll’s ankle.

—Krrk.

The Hunters surrounded the staggering Troll. Scraping together the last of their mana, they poured it into their weapons. Dozens of blades hacked the monster to pieces.

Thump! Crack-crack-crack!

We’d fought against overwhelming numbers. The Hunters had suffered heavy losses, and the blood they’d shed had to be repaid in monsters.

“Die! Die!”

Hoarse shouts rang out here and there, voices raw from exhaustion and excitement.

The Hunters spat on the Troll’s corpse, chopped as fine as ground meat, then moved on with bloodshot eyes to find their next prey.

Boom! Boom-boom-boom!

Attack spells rained down.

Even now, thousands of monsters trampled corpses and their own kind as they surged south like a wave. The Hunters stood in their path like an enormous reef.

And I was at its center.

Whoosh!

A single diagonal downward sweep.

A razor-sharp gust shot along the spearhead and swept past the fleeing monsters.

Shraaaak.

Blood burst out instead of a scream, soaking into the sand.

But those lucky enough to escape the attack’s reach put more distance between us and ran faster.

Monsters had never even thought of their own kind as kin. Survival mattered more than fighting now, and they fled for their lives. Countless others were already scattering in every direction, slipping out of the encirclement.

I can’t let them get away. I have to take down as many as I can.

The battle was over. What we'd achieved would be remembered for generations and recorded in history as a great victory.

But more than five thousand monsters remained.

We'd killed so many, yet there were still enough to be called an army. Letting them escape today would leave the seeds of another disaster.

Still, we can't chase them right now.

Everyone was exhausted from a long and brutal battle. Right now, the only things driving the Hunters were their anger and desire for revenge against the monsters. Nothing more, nothing less.

And I wasn't the only one thinking it.

"Human!"

"Jin!"

The Skeleton King, who'd been holding the rear, and Magic Johnson, who'd fought his way through the monsters to reach me, came up on either side.

"We need to regroup as quickly as we can, then pursue them," Magic Johnson said, short of breath. "We should split our forces into separate units."

The Skeleton King cut down an injured ogre that had fallen behind before answering.

"I agree. My magical power is nearly depleted, but we can't let this chance pass. I've already turned several Griffins into undead. They'll give us enough of a view."

I started to answer, then caught my breath. I steadied my ragged breathing and managed only a nod. The Skeleton King frowned.

"Human, are you all right?"

"It's… it's nothing. Don't worry about it."

A lie.

My arms and legs felt as heavy as if they'd been soaked in water. The internal energy that had filled my dantian was running low.

More than anything, the dull ache I'd felt deep inside my body on and off throughout the battle was growing worse.

Damn debuff.

I kept my expression calm by force and recalled a System message I'd seen not long ago. It was among the notifications waiting for me when I'd woken from my long sleep after defeating Michael Silbert.

SYSTEM

All things come with a price. But you have once again ignored repeated warnings and used power that surpasses your limits.
Information for the special debuff Broken Body has been updated.
The special debuff Shattered Body has been newly applied. The existing stat penalties caused by debuffs remain unchanged, and the effects of the new debuff will also apply.
Muscles and Bones have weakened. The chance of injury has increased considerably.
Internal energy is consumed more rapidly. Your control over qi is no longer as free as before.

Shattered Body.

That was the price of ignoring the System's warning.

One Annihilation's unprecedented destructive power had eaten away at my body as well as my enemy's life. It was damage no method could heal—not even leveling up.

Should I have avoided using One Annihilation against Michael Silbert?

The thought left a bitter taste in my mouth, but there was nothing I could do about it. Back then, I hadn't had much choice beyond One Annihilation.

I pushed aside the potion Magic Johnson held out with a worried look.

"That won't do it. If I use a potion now, I'll only end up more exhausted."

"But—"

"Pursuing them comes first. Especially…"

"Yes. The Prophet."

The Skeleton King spoke quietly. He read the meaning in my eyes and clicked his tongue.

"We still haven't found him. I was certain he was watching from somewhere, but it seems we were wrong."

Magic Johnson added, "I haven't found him either. Jin, maybe The Prophet was never here at all."

"Never here? You mean this was a trap aimed at something else from the start?"

"I can't be sure. But it's possible."

I thought for a moment, then shook my head.

Four S-rank monsters and an army of more than fifteen thousand monsters. That was far too much to use as bait for a mere trap.

So why hasn't he shown himself?

The Prophet was an unpredictable powerhouse. He'd killed Siegfried Bassmann, a Grand Mage surrounded by all kinds of barriers, without leaving any obvious signs of a fight. He might be as powerful as Michael Silbert—or more so.

If he'd joined the battle, who knows how it would have turned out?

Even for me, fighting the Manticore Lord and the Lycanthrope Champion at once had been anything but easy. That would have been the perfect moment for The Prophet to show himself.

But he never did.

Even if the battle had been a trap and our main camp was his true target, it still made no sense.

Embarrassing as it was to say, I was the heart and head of the World Hunter Federation.

That left me with one conclusion.

"It's not a trap."

My thoughts had run long, but only a moment had passed. I looked at the Hunters still chasing the monsters like mad.

The Team Leaders—our lower-ranking commanders—were ordering them to stop, but the Hunters pursued their prey as though they couldn't hear a word.

"I don't know what The Prophet really wants, but… he planned for this situation, too."

"What?"

"If we keep pursuing them without rest, the units will fall apart in no time. First, get the worked-up Hunters back under control as quickly as you can."

"Jin."

Magic Johnson fixed me with a grave look.

"I agree we need to regroup. But then why did The Prophet drive all those monsters into this desert?"

"One of two reasons. Either he thought they'd be enough to deal with us…"

I stopped, then forced out the rest.

"Or he's already built a force so powerful he can afford to lose an army this size."

"…!"

"…!"

The air around us went cold.

I looked at their rigid faces and kept one thought to myself.

One thing was certain. My instincts, pushed to their limit, had seized me with the force of a premonition.

The Prophet wants to face me.

The monsters' cries receded into the distance. Only then, among the people collapsing one by one, did a wind begin to blow.

Heavy with the smell of blood, it spread through the cool night air.

One hundred and eighty-five.

That was how many people had fought more bravely than anyone else—and, because of that, had crossed a river they could never come back over.

But the survivors had to keep moving.

We hadn't come here to win a battle. We'd come to kill The Prophet and uproot the disaster.

There's no time.

The idea that the person running is more desperate than the one giving chase is complete bullshit. Especially when the person running has a bomb that could swallow the whole world.

"Everyone has finished regrouping."

I opened my eyes at Team Leader Choi's report.

I'd spent less than an hour circulating my energy, but my body felt much better. My mind had settled, too.

What the hell is The Prophet?

I'd been asking myself that for a long time.

The fifth Muninn. A being thought to be a monster, wielding magic that wasn't human. The desert's pope, leading countless fanatics.

The more I learned about him, the more I felt as if I were sinking into a swamp. What was he really? What did he want? And where was he now?

If the System had a physical form, I wanted to grab it by the collar and demand answers.

I'd take any debuff it gave me. Just give me one tiny clue.

Damn it.

I cursed under my breath and looked up at the darkening sky.

Daylight in the desert was brief, and the sky was gray, perhaps because of the distribution of magical power.

Just like Michael Silbert.

The monster who had been born human and died a monster.

And as my memories of him surfaced, one after another—

"…!"

A question flashed through my mind like a bolt of light.

Chapter 810

Perhaps intuition was another name for wisdom.

The feeling of an instinct etched into every cell suddenly waking. Of countless thoughts tangled in your head coming together as one.

“Michael Silbert. Michael Silbert. Michael…”

The name should have stayed in Jin Taekyung’s mind. Instead, it slipped from his lips without him noticing.

A question filled his mind in an instant. New thoughts followed, one after another. Each time a question came back to him with an answer, he sent it out again carrying another question.

And each time, the same words came first.

What if. Suppose. Maybe…

He questioned and questioned without pause, until the thoughts tangling in his head took on something like a coherent shape.

He had no idea how much time passed.

And…

He was so deeply absorbed that he didn’t notice someone’s footsteps—whose, he couldn’t tell—drawing close.

Crunch.

Sand shifted underfoot. Jin’s senses snapped awake.

The hairs on his body stood on end, and instinct moved him before his brain could give the order.

Whoosh.

He spun, slashing downward with his spear.

He’d made that move thousands—tens of thousands—of times in training and combat. It was etched into him, terrifyingly fast and precise. Fast enough to make the intruder in the darkness think of death.

But the intruder was no pushover.

Vwooom.

A flash of light accompanied an invisible ripple of qi. The space around them brightened, and Jin’s eyes widened as he recognized who stood before him.

“…!”

Recognition brought control. His strike, hurtling forward with tremendous speed and force, stopped as if someone had pressed pause.

The spearhead halted a hair’s breadth from a faintly glowing, translucent barrier. A fierce gust swept through.

Fwoooosh!

Sand that had somehow escaped the blood flew into the air. The intruder spat some of it out of his mouth.

"Do me a favor. If you're going to kill me, tell me first. Give me a little time to prepare."

Jin lowered his spear and hurriedly asked, "Damn it. I'm sorry, Johnson. Are you hurt anywhere?"

"…As you can see."

Magic Johnson dispelled his defensive spell. He barely managed to get the words out. In those few moments, cold sweat had gathered on the back of his neck, glistening in the faint moonlight.

"I'm fine. Though I might've had a little accident."

"What?"

"Before you get the wrong idea, everything about me is big. Just this once, it was only a little."

Jin let out a relieved breath at the joke.

That had been truly dangerous. If he hadn't stopped the spearhead at the last moment, there would definitely have been blood.

"I'm sorry again."

"I said it's fine. More importantly, Jin, what the hell was that?"

"What was what?"

"Why you mistook a wonderful friend and comrade-in-arms like me for an enemy. What were you thinking about just now?"

"Ah, well…"

Jin started to answer, then suddenly shut his mouth.

Johnson studied him for a moment and shrugged. "You don't have to tell me. If our young boss can't talk about it, I'm sure he has his reasons. But there's one thing I do have to say."

"If there's something you have to say…"

"We finished regrouping nearly thirty minutes ago. Whatever's troubling you, if we delay the pursuit any longer, we'll lose them for good. That's why I came."

What? Already?

Only then did Jin belatedly check the time and bite his lip. Everything Magic Johnson had said was true.

When did that much time pass?

It felt like less than a minute had passed since Choi Minwoo stopped by, but the sky had grown darker in the meantime.

I must've had a lot on my mind.

No-self wasn't a state that belonged only to martial arts. Jin had been so absorbed in one question after another that he hadn't noticed time passing. Johnson had no way of guessing why he'd stayed rooted to the spot.

"I know their deaths are weighing on you. That's why I gave you a little time. But Jin, if we lose them now or fail to find The Prophet… remember, the sacrifices made up to this point will have been for nothing."

Pat, pat.

Magic Johnson patted Jin on the shoulder with his large hand, then turned away after leaving him with one last remark.

"Everyone's waiting. We need you, Boss."

That was all.

Jin watched the Grand Mage's back slowly recede and wondered how much truth was in the questions he'd come up with. What, exactly, was a lie, and what was the truth?

He steadied his breathing.

"No. Either way, there's only one path."

He'd barely managed to grasp a single clue. With no other choice, there was no point in thinking it over any longer.

Jin took a heavy step into the darkness surrounding them.

The desert night was cold, dark, and vast.

No one complained. They walked in silence.

One hundred and eighty-five.

We'd fought shoulder to shoulder with them, even if only for a short time, and lost them. Some had been strangers; others must have been close. We'd buried their bodies in the dunes, then had to leave them behind.

In place of gravestones worthy of heroes, we planted their bloodied weapons in the sand. We swore we would return to these coordinates and bring them home to their families.

That promise was why the survivors kept moving. I led the way.

Whoooooosh!

Countless figures sped across the desert.

Sand carried on the wind stung my face. But sand wasn't all the wind carried.

The stench of blood. And a foul odor.

The smell was sickening, but familiar. Sticky liquid coated the plants and rocks we passed.

Blue-green blood. Monster blood.

Where are you?

I spread the energy coiled inside me over a wide area. At the same time, I sensed faint breaths and the traces of an unpleasant magical power.

"Shen."

I stopped. Xiao Shen understood at once, drew his sword in a flash, and drove it deep into the ground beneath his feet.

Squish!

Blood spurted from the sand as it suddenly caved in. At the same time, the ground all around us rippled like waves.

Shhhhh!

Monsters appeared for an instant amid the flying sand. An urgent shout rang through the night.

"Ant Lion!"

Colloquially known as the antlion.

Even the smallest specimen was about the size of a midsize car, and these powerful monsters were classified as at least Grade B.

But the one that had just appeared had larger pincers and more powerful mana than any Ant Lion I'd ever seen.

It's one of the ones that fled the battle earlier.

It was one of more than a hundred Grade A monsters that had saved their lives by retreating from the battlefield.

I moved as soon as I realized it.

Tap.

The twenty meters[3231] between us vanished. As the Ant Lion lunged to swallow the nearest Hunters, I brought my spear down.

Shhk!

One strike. Both pincers, harder than steel, sliced off like tofu.

Before its anguished scream could even ring out, I twisted the spear shaft in midair and slammed it into the monster's body.

Crack!

Blood sprayed out with a nauseating stench. The blow wasn't enough to kill it.

I pressed the spearhead against the spot I guessed was between its eyes and moved my lips.

The language of monsters.

"A few questions. Think carefully before you answer."

"…!"

Scholars who studied the Demon Realm language existed. Humans who could speak it fluently were rarer than Named Monsters.

[3231] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

The Ant Lion's eyes, clouded with pain, flew open. It clearly hadn't expected this.

"You. Human. How?"

I tightened my grip on White Flame instead of answering.

Shhk.

As the keen spearhead cut smoothly through skin as hard as armor, a panicked voice burst out.

"I answer! Anything! Ask!"

Judging from its clumsy Demon Realm language, it wasn't very intelligent—but it was quick to catch on. I stopped the spearhead.

"Where are the others?"

"Gone. All. Sun falls that way."

"West?"

"Yes! There. Many!"

I had no reason to doubt it. The Ant Lion was stupid enough that everything it said rang true.

West.

Some must have fallen behind or scattered along the way, but most of the monsters that had left the battlefield had undoubtedly headed west.

What I really wanted to know was something else.

"Then what about The Prophet?"

"The Prophet?"

"Yes. The Prophet."

The Ant Lion blinked its round eyes.

"What is that? I don't know."

I clicked my tongue as I realized my mistake. The Prophet had revealed that name to the world himself. Unless the monster army had gathered somewhere in the desert to watch TV, this creature wouldn't know it.

"Let me rephrase. Not The Prophet. Your leader—the commander leading you and the other monsters."

"Commander? Leader? Leads us?"

It repeated my words haltingly, then looked up at me with fear and confusion in its eyes.

"Dead. You. You all killed them."

"What?"

"One. Two. Three. Four. All dead. Me, everyone, scared. So ran."

I looked into its eyes and confirmed once more that it wasn't lying.

"Right. I see."

"Me, me, believe! Didn't lie!"

"I know."

I pushed the spearhead deep between the Ant Lion's eyes and added calmly, "I know how many people died because of you, too."

Crunch. Gurgle.

The monster's enormous body shuddered as blood bubbled from it.

A System notification announced another death. I shook the blood and bodily fluids from my spear.

Johnson came over once he saw the interrogation was finished. "What did it say?"

I answered in a dry voice. "No luck. It didn't even know The Prophet existed."

"…Damn it. Well, it'd be strange for a Grade A monster—not even Grade S—to know all that. Did you find out where the ones that ran off are headed?"

"Yes."

"Where?"

I stared at Magic Johnson without answering. Then I replied as if it were nothing.

"East."

Over his shoulder, the Skeleton King stared at me, eyes wide.

Chapter 811

"East. You mean east."

Magic Johnson turned his head to check the direction. For the Skeleton King, that was unfortunate.

He had to fight to hide the shock on his face. The shock filling his mind was harder to shake.

Why on earth?

To the Skeleton King, a monster, the Demon Realm language was practically his mother tongue.

Unlike Magic Johnson, who had been watching the rear of the formation, he'd stayed beside Jin Taekyung at the front the whole time. He'd heard enough of the conversation to understand it perfectly.

The Ant Lion said most of the monsters went west. I'm sure of it.

His thoughts tangled together. Jin Taekyung's expression hadn't changed in the slightest, and for a moment the Skeleton King wondered if he'd misheard. But no. However many times he went over the exchange, his memory stayed the same.

That vile human… lied.

So what did Jin Taekyung's lie, and this situation now, mean?

After a brief moment of thought, the Skeleton King found the answer himself. It was the answer he'd already suspected and had tried so hard to ignore.

No way.

His pupils trembled as he faced what he could scarcely believe. Just then, Magic Johnson looked away from the darkened east and turned toward him.

"Did you send your minions east to search—hey. Are you listening to me?"

"Hm? Oh. Of course."

"What were you looking at?"

The Skeleton King had looked at Jin Taekyung without realizing it, but he couldn't say so. The instant he heard Magic Johnson's voice, his heart had lurched. He forced himself to settle down, then gestured with his chin toward the dead Ant Lion's corpse.

"That one. I thought it might move well if I brought it back as an undead."

"Hmm, not a bad idea. But it burrows deep into the sand, so humans like us couldn't ride it. And aboveground, its size would make it too conspicuous."

"Then I'll give up on it. Come to think of it, controlling something like that would take a lot of magical power."

Had he answered convincingly? Had Magic Johnson noticed anything strange about his behavior?

As Johnson slowly stroked his chin, the Skeleton King pushed down his anxiety and hurriedly continued.

"But what were you going to ask?"

"Oh, right. I was going to ask if you'd sent your minions to search the east."

"The eagles and griffins?"

"Right. Didn't they already go out and come back? If the monsters fled east, I'd have thought they would've spotted them."

Magic Johnson was right. The Skeleton King had already sent his subordinates east.

While everyone else regrouped and rested, a dozen or so eagles and griffins had taken to the sky after the monster army fleeing frantically across the desert. His magical power had soon run low, ending the undead's pursuit without results. But he knew, at least, that few monsters had gone east.

"Well…"

His voice trailed off. Beside Magic Johnson, Jin Taekyung watched him with a dark, steady gaze.

Damn it.

The Skeleton King didn't know if the choice he was about to make was right.

Then he remembered something Jin Taekyung had once said—words that had calmed not only him, but everyone around him.

If you can't trust yourself, trust me.

He recalled the words and repeated them to himself. In that instant, his hesitation ended.

"I lost sight of them quickly, but there's a good chance most of the monster army fled east."

The Skeleton King trusted Jin Taekyung's judgment—no, his friend's judgment.

Perhaps more than his own.

Even before we met the Ant Lion, I'd put the conflict lingering in the back of my mind aside.

Now all I had to do was tug on the thread I'd barely managed to grasp and find out what lay at the other end.

But I can't do that right away.

I had to be meticulous. I couldn't leave them an opening.

I sorted out my thoughts, then gathered a few of the people in command.

"We'll split up our forces and move out."

My abrupt announcement sent a ripple of unease through the group. Team Leader Choi was the first to object.

"Weren't we all going east together?"

Most of the monsters had headed east. That was what everyone except the Skeleton King and me believed, so his question made sense.

Assuming what they believed was true.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes?"

"When did I say that?"

"But…"

"I know what you mean."

My voice came out dry, so unlike my usual voice that it sounded strange even to me. I looked at Team Leader Choi's stiff face and went on.

"But we can't act on the Ant Lion's information as if we know it's true. It's too dangerous."

"You mean it could be a deliberate trap?"

"Yes."

It struck me again: I was pretty good at lying.

I also knew a truth I'd learned in both Murim and the modern world.

Authority.

A lie told by someone with authority is remarkably persuasive. People who trust that person are ready to believe it.

Just like now.

"They lost the battle and ran, but they still outnumber us by more than five to one."

Five thousand.

An army that had numbered well over ten thousand had been cut to a third in a single battle. But we'd taken losses, too.

Even with an overwhelming kill ratio, the two hundred or so people we'd lost amounted to a fifth of our force.

If the monster army was a pie too big to finish in one sitting, we were a muffin someone could swallow whole.

"We need to be careful. We should split up and pursue them."

Xiao Shen nodded.

"I agree with Sir Jin. If we act on false information, we could walk into a trap—or head the wrong way and lose the monsters."

"Exactly. Splitting up would lower the risk."

Team Leader Choi furrowed his brow.

"I understand why you want to split up, but… wouldn't that leave the units vulnerable to being picked off one by one?"

Any commander would worry about that, but the chance of it happening was extremely low.

The monsters fled west, not east.

I swallowed the words on the tip of my tongue and answered without hesitation.

"We'll keep the units close together. Even with communications disrupted by the high concentration of magical power, we should still be able to maintain a reliable connection."

"Hmm. I agree with Jin," Magic Johnson said. "By my rough calculation, a hundred kilometers[3232] or so between units should be close enough."

I looked at him in silence, then answered with a heavy heart.

"That's right. We'll cover more ground, too."

The Rub' al Khali Desert was said to be the second-largest desert in the world. Its size was staggering.

Even Team Leader Choi seemed to realize anew how large it was. He reluctantly nodded.

"If we assign a hundred people to each pursuit unit… we could cover the southeast and northeast as well as the east. Understood. There's no time to waste, so let's move quickly."

He was about to leave, but turned back before he'd taken a step.

"You've left one thing out," I said.

"Mr. Jin Taekyung, what do you mean—"

"West. I'm sending a pursuit unit west, too."

"What?"

"But that's the opposite direction."

"That's right."

I looked around at everyone.

"But if we travel a few more hours west from here, we'll reach the oil fields. The very place the message The Prophet left for me points to."

"…!"

"You heard the message yourself," I said to Yamamoto Genji. "Tell them. Am I right?"

He'd looked miserable ever since I mentioned splitting up. Now everyone was watching him. He glanced around nervously and nodded.

"Uh, well. He said it was a land where black jewels were buried, so I think that's probably right…"

"Good enough. We're going west."

"Wait. We are?"

[3232] A hundred kilometers is about 62 miles.

“Yes. You, me, the Skeleton King, and Magic Johnson.”

Yamamoto Genji’s face went deathly pale.

“Jin Sama[3233]! How can you do this?”

“Right here.”

“That’s ridiculous… Leave me out of it! I want to stay with the others!”

“No. I won’t leave you out. I have no intention of leaving you out. Go back.”

After answering firmly, I continued speaking to the people who were blinking at this unexpected turn of events.

“We didn’t come here for the monster army. We came for The Prophet. We need to follow his message at least as far as the place it points to. We’ll be back soon. Until then, keep pursuing the remaining monsters, but avoid a clash.”

“No!”

Team Leader Choi, who’d been staring at me blankly, shouted in protest.

“If The Prophet was in the west all along, why would the monsters run the exact opposite way?”

“That’s true. But if most of them don’t know The Prophet exists, like the Ant Lion, they have every reason to run east.”

“Mr. Jin Taekyung. Do you really believe The Prophet is there?”

“I don’t know. But even if he isn’t, you and the others will still be pursuing the monsters, so nothing will go wrong. And if he’s in the west… we’ll have enough strength to take him on.”

Three S-rank Hunters.

No, four, if we counted the Skeleton King. And with his abilities, he could bring undead soldiers into the fight.

“But…”

Just as he parted his lips to say something, I delivered the final blow.

“This is an order.”

“…!”

“Hurry. Before the monsters get any farther away.”

I turned away. Then I sent a Sound Transmission, as though in passing, to someone who’d stood there without a word all this time.

—From now on, don’t answer or react to anything I say. Just listen.

For a brief moment, the Skeleton King’s eyes, which had been trembling violently, settled into a deep stillness.

[3233] *Sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing a high degree of respect.

After that one-sided discussion, I spent a short while circulating my qi, then set out west.

I wasn't alone. The Skeleton King, Magic Johnson, and Yamamoto Genji came with me.

There were only four of us, but we were a powerful force, and we moved at a speed that couldn't compare to when we'd been traveling with the army.

Whoosh!

Amid the scenery flashing past, I spotted pools of thick, sticky blood. I didn't have to stop and examine them to see how much had been shed, or how far the trail spread.

A few dozen monsters couldn't have left all this behind. Everything the Ant Lion had said was true.

Though that's not the important part.

I kept running, muttering to myself. We crossed rolling dunes and passed through an open stretch of wilderness.

After about thirty minutes, we reached a canyon between two facing cliffs. Only then did I begin to slow.

"Hah… Hah. C-could you slow down a little?"

Yamamoto Genji was panting. Magic Johnson wiped his sweat-soaked forehead and spoke to me.

"Jin. How about we rest here for a bit? I don't see any monsters around."

Instead of answering, I came to a complete stop and slowly looked around.

Cliffs stretching into the distance. A narrow passage. Good terrain.

Little room to move. A narrow escape route.

I looked up at the sky. In the distance, I saw a shadow flapping its wings against the faint moonlight over the desert.

An eagle.

Magic Johnson followed my gaze and frowned.

"Still birds out here? With this concentration of magical power, they should hardly be able to live here."

"Not impossible, if they aren't ordinary eagles."

"What?"

Magic Johnson blinked, not understanding. I stepped in front of the canyon entrance and blocked the way.

Chapter 812

Step.

Jin Taekyung felt the earth crumble beneath his foot and wondered why his footsteps sounded so loud. Was it the depth of the night? Or was it because every nerve in his body was on edge?

He didn't know. Maybe it was both.

But one thing was certain. From this moment on, no one would leave this long, narrow canyon without his permission.

"Jin?"

Magic Johnson stared at him, apparently unable to understand why the air had suddenly grown so heavy. Then he turned his head.

Beneath the moonlight spilling down the towering cliffs, a figure stood blocking the exit, its golden eyes gleaming.

The Skeleton King.

Johnson's lips silently formed the name. As he realized the position he was in, the Grand Mage's gaze darkened.

"What does this mean?"

"Nothing in particular. I just have a few things I need to check."

Jin's tone was gentle, but his eyes were cold.

The eagle in the distance was already forgotten. Magic Johnson studied him.

"If it isn't urgent, why not check later?"

"It's urgent. I have to check now."

"Caution is a leader's virtue. But I don't think now is the right time."

"I can see why you'd think that. But isn't judging the right time exactly what a leader does?"

Magic Johnson fell silent for a moment, then gave a quiet laugh.

"You're right, Jin. I didn't know you were so good with words."

"I've noticed this now and then, but test scores and running your mouth are two different things."

Jin smiled faintly along with him, then called out a name.

"Genji."

"Y-yes?"

Yamamoto Genji, who had been watching from beside Magic Johnson, jumped at the sudden call.

He'd already realized something was wrong. As his eyes darted around, Jin jerked his chin at him.

"You look uncomfortable. Come over here. You're getting on my nerves."

"Y-yes, sir!"

Yamamoto glanced at Magic Johnson and took a step forward. When the hulking Grand Mage didn't react, he hurried over to Jin's side.

"U-um. Jin-sama.[3234] What exactly is going on…"

"Shut up."

Jin answered calmly, then looked at Magic Johnson.

Johnson's expression hadn't changed despite the sudden turn of events. He was still sitting on the rough rock.

"Johnson. When did we first meet?"

The question came out of nowhere, but Magic Johnson answered readily.

"During the Arch Lich subjugation. It hasn't even been a year."

"It feels strange. It seems like it's been ten years already."

"A lot has happened. Things we thought would never happen again—things we couldn't even imagine."

"Yeah. I really didn't think things would turn out like this."

Jin smiled bitterly. Two years ago—no, even just a year ago—he'd been nothing more than an unusually talented F-rank Hunter.

He'd never escaped the confines fate had set for him when he awakened. He'd spent his days in a cramped, musty goshiwon room.[3235]

But everything had changed.

Last summer had been unusually hot. One day, without warning, he'd been told he was fired.

And then… there was the beat-up capsule waiting for him on the melting asphalt.

Every moment was still vivid.

That night, the beat-up capsule had tossed the fool who'd been reckless enough to crawl inside it for a nap into a new world. Jin had escaped his confines and changed his fate.

"Things we couldn't even imagine. That's probably the best way to put it. I know because I've lived through them. But you know what's funny?"

Jin didn't wait for an answer.

The faint smile had vanished from his lips. They were now as rough and hard as the rock Magic Johnson sat on.

"After going through so many things I couldn't have imagined, my imagination still barely improves."

A being called the Demon King had descended upon Earth. Countless monsters had burned cities and slaughtered people.

[3234] *-sama* is a Japanese honorific expressing high respect.

[3235] A goshiwon is a small, inexpensive room-for-rent lodging, often with very little space.

Humanity had won after five years of the Great War, then built an even more brilliant and vast civilization.

Impossible things. And yet, they'd happened to everyone just a few decades ago.

Jin hadn't lived through that era, but he'd crossed dimensions, traveled between two worlds, and gained no shortage of experience.

"Sometimes I think common sense is terrifying. It keeps you thinking inside the same old box, and you end up going nowhere."

Jin tapped his temple with a dagger he'd drawn at some point.

Magic Johnson had watched in silence. Now he spoke.

"So this time, you used your imagination a little more?"

"Yes. I went back over everything that's happened so far. Slowly. From as objective a perspective as I could manage."

"Jin, humans can't be objective."

Magic Johnson was right.

People's judgments were always subjective. Ironically, humanity had become the master of the world because, more than any other creature on Earth, it was made up of thought and emotion.

But…

"I found I could at least try. Set aside what I know and how I feel about someone as much as possible."

"Right. You can try to look at things objectively. That's humanity's greatest strength."

"Hmm."

Jin licked his lips.

"That's a dangerous thing to say."

"Which part?"

"I don't know. You make it sound like you're not human yourself."

Jin's reflection shone in Magic Johnson's clear eyes. A short laugh slipped from Johnson's lips, breaking the silence.

"So, Jin. Did you achieve what you wanted?"

"Probably."

Magic Johnson already knew what Jin had gone to such lengths to work out.

"The Prophet."

Johnson's deep voice carried through the night air. Jin gave a small nod.

"I started with the person most closely connected to him."

"Michael Silbert. Considering their connection, that would be the obvious place to start."

“Huginn called The Prophet Muninn. The fifth Muninn, at that. One of the beings swapped out like spare parts to make Michael Silbert who he is today. And on top of that, The Prophet uses magic that isn’t human.”

“That’s why we suspected he was a monster.”

“Right. But isn’t something strange? Huginn only learned about the fifth Muninn three years ago, yet Michael Silbert had been handling magical power little by little since the Great Cataclysm.”

“What’s strange about that?”

“Of course it’s strange. A human made magical power and mana coexist. That’s insane. Even I can’t do it now. And that guy did it thirty years ago? No way.”

Then Jin added, “Unless a real monster helped him.”

Magic Johnson paused. Jin went on.

“But the timing didn’t add up. Three years ago and thirty years ago. There was too much time in between.”

“…”

“After thinking it over, I came up with one answer.”

Jin scratched his chin with the dagger. A week without shaving had left him with patchy stubble, and the sharp blade scraped it away.

“The Prophet isn’t the fifth Muninn.”

Shhk.

The instant a drop of blood rolled from the tip of his chin, where the blade had nicked him, a chilly voice pierced everyone’s ears.

“For more than thirty years, there has been only one Muninn.”

“…!”

“…!”

The air around them seemed to chill. Jin shook the blood from his dagger and continued.

“Once I thought of it that way, things finally started to add up. What the fuck, this isn’t a claw machine. I couldn’t understand how people that powerful and loyal kept popping up every few years.”

Yamamoto Genji, who had been listening with wide eyes, let his mouth fall open.

“Th-then…”

“Yeah. The Prophet taught Michael Silbert how to handle magical power, and they worked together toward their own goals. He must’ve been incredibly powerful even thirty years ago.”

The scattered pieces began to fall into place, one by one. Jin Taekyung’s voice became an unseen hand, feeling its way over countless pieces.

One. Two. Three. Ten.

Each piece filled a space that matched its shape. As they came together, the outline of someone began to emerge.

It was a portrait. It was also a puzzle.

But…

Not enough. Not nearly enough.

Too many questions remained unanswered for Jin to complete it.

Lose even one piece, and a puzzle could never be whole. This one had gaps everywhere. Filling them was nearly impossible.

At least, it was impossible for Jin to do alone.

“Johnson.”

Jin spoke without warning.

The Grand Mage had risen from the rock. His shadow loomed large, and the staff in his hand gleamed in the moonlight.

“Can I ask you one thing?”

“Anything, Jin.”

“Why have you helped me all this time?”

“Because we’re friends.”

“Like Siegfried Bassmann?”

Magic Johnson raised his staff as he answered.

“Yeah.”

“I hesitated until the end. Honestly, even now I’m not sure. It makes no sense for a monster to use mana and even potions.”

“Anyone would think that if they were human. But there’s nothing in this world that can’t happen.”

Vwooom.

The Magic Gem at the tip of the staff began to vibrate. It was an S-rank Magic Gem, obtained by killing a monster that had slaughtered an entire city on its own during the Great Cataclysm.

Feeling the enormous flow of mana surging with the wind, Jin Taekyung suddenly spoke.

“Do you remember what you said earlier?”

Magic Johnson gave a heavy nod.

“I remember. Humans can’t be objective.”

“You were right. I’m only human, so I couldn’t help thinking subjectively.”

“Everyone does. He’s a bit of an unusual case, but that friend is the same.”

Magic Johnson gestured with his chin behind him.

Beyond the Skeleton King, who wore a golden crown made of magical power, hundreds of pairs of eyes gleamed throughout the canyon.

“Then sending the other forces east was…”

“I didn’t want people who had nothing to do with this getting caught up in it.”

“Excellent. Was that your decision?”

“Yes, but…”

Jin Taekyung raised the dagger in his hand and continued.

“It wasn’t just a subjective judgment.”

And at that moment—

Flash!

A blinding light burst from Jin’s eyes.

Everyone who faced the sudden flash in the darkness froze for an instant.

Everyone but Jin. He was the one who had called forth the light, the one who had wanted it.

Crack! Stab!

The dagger shot forward like a beam of light, smashing through armor and tearing through flesh and bone. Jin watched Yamamoto Genji stagger.

“What the hell are you?”

Yamamoto Genji’s eyes widened in disbelief.

Then he—no, The Prophet—grinned.

Chapter 813

Fwoosh.

Everything sharpened and slowed.

Dirt and sand flew up beneath his staggering feet. His eyes widened. Blood surged from his chest.

And then…

“What the fuck are you?”

As the words left my mouth, time returned to normal.

I could see Yamamoto Genji—or rather, the bastard wearing his face—grinning.

The Prophet.

A moment ago, his eyes had been wide with pain. Now they gleamed with joy and surprise I couldn’t understand.

He’s happy? Now?

I pushed the question aside and swung my dagger again.

The Prophet staggered, clutching his bleeding chest. The moment his hand closed around the hilt at his waist, a slash leaped from my dagger and flashed through the darkness ahead of him.

Shhk.

A faint line appeared across The Prophet’s wrist with a chilling cut.

His right hand, which had half-drawn the sword, lost its strength and fell away from his body.

Thud. Splatter!

Blood sprayed onto the ground. Red blood, no different from any human’s. That only made it harder to believe what I was seeing, even as I charged him.

Whoosh. Crack!

I brought my heel down on his leg with the force of a thousand geun.[3236] The flesh of his calf burst, and the bones beneath it shattered.

The Prophet dropped to one knee, his balance gone. He reached for me with his remaining hand, but this time I didn’t have to move.

“Stop.”

A deep voice rang out. The wind died, and the air trembled.

I couldn’t see the force that caught The Prophet’s wrist before his hand reached me, but I could feel the Grand Mage’s powerful mana surrounding us.

Crack.

[3236] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

His hand stopped dead in midair. Bones ground out of place, and his brow twisted. Then his body began to rise, as if an invisible giant had seized him and lifted him off the ground.

Whistle—thud, thud, thud!

Something pure white shot toward him like a beam of light and pierced his limbs.

The long, sharp bone shards sliced through flesh and bone like tofu, pinning his body—which had been floating in the air—deep into the cliff.

Crunch!

The solid rock, which might have stood there for hundreds or even thousands of years, held him fast.

Overpowered in an instant after my surprise attack, The Prophet coughed up a mouthful of blood.

"Cough. Heh heh."

Pain was the same for everyone.

But The Prophet laughed, curling his bloodstained lips as if he couldn't feel a thing.

"Good. First, I'll give you credit. Very well done."

Wham!

A blow to the face snapped his head back. His skull struck the cliff with a boom, and he shook his head.

"It's been a while since I felt my head ring. Having fun is one thing, but let's not overdo it."

"…!"

I stifled a groan.

I'd already cut off his hand and crushed his knee. My first strike had driven straight toward his heart, too. He'd pulled away at the last moment, but the tremendous Scorching Yang Qi carried by my dagger had been enough to ravage his insides.

An ordinary human would be dead by now.

But The Prophet wasn't an ordinary human. That impossible vitality couldn't belong to one.

And unlike Michael Silbert, who had been practically half-human and half-demon, then died in the form of a monster while bleeding monster's blood, The Prophet was still shedding red human blood.

"…Jin."

"What… what the hell is that thing?"

Magic Johnson and the Skeleton King stared at the incomprehensible being, their gazes trembling. The Prophet laughed, his voice thick with blood.

"No one can answer that. That's the kind of being I am."

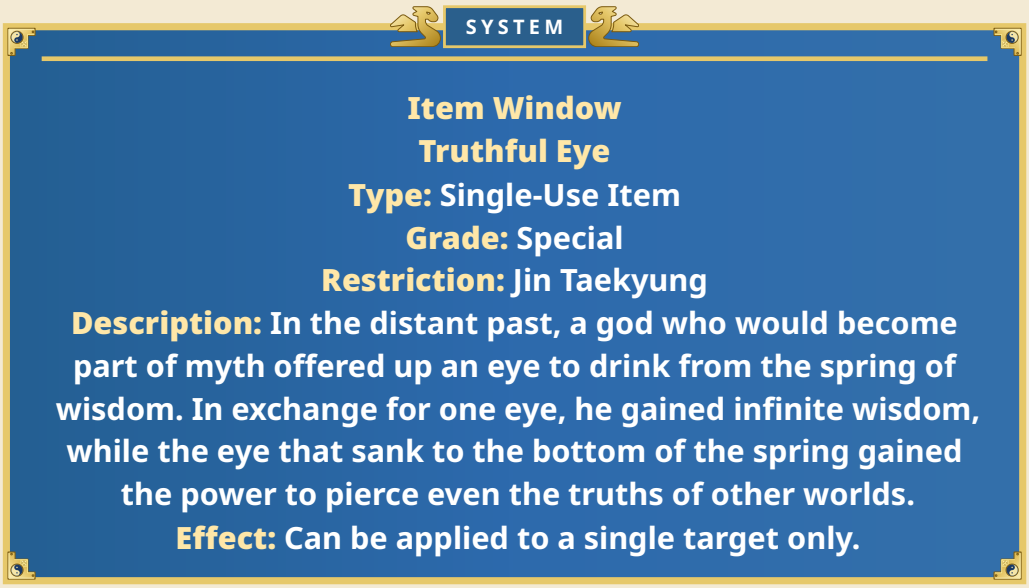
No. He was wrong.

I steadied my ragged breathing. My eyes gave off a faint glow and burned as if they were on fire.

This was the price of briefly taking in a power beyond humanity. It was also a gift the System had given one foolish human—and the only key to this enormous puzzle.

The Truthful Eye.

I'd received the special Item as a Reward for completing **Unknown Death**, the Quest that began with Siegfried Bassmann's death. I'd only glanced at its details before, but the moment I found a clue, I'd recalled them.



Looking back, the System had always shown me the way.

At first, I hadn't known what the consumable Item called the Truthful Eye was for. I hadn't known what the hologram only I could see was trying to tell me.

But now I did.

A few hours ago, I'd found my one clue. Before that, the System had already handed me the key to understanding it.

A key that could be used on only one target—and therefore had to be used with even greater care.

And now I held the power to see through every truth.

Fwoooosh.

Heat flooded my eyes. My vision turned white.

But the divine power within them pushed through the pain and reached out.

Toward Yamamoto Genji. Toward the pope of the fanatics who had built a temple in this desert.

Toward the unknown being who had spent more than thirty years sowing the seeds of catastrophe in this land under the name Muninn—and now meant to bring them to flower himself.

A thick veil hid him, one even Qi Sense couldn't penetrate. But the eye of the old god called Odin saw through it all.

Pierced it. Revealed what lay beneath.

Flash!

The instant a distant, blinding light flooded my vision, countless bells thrashed inside my mind.

System notifications I'd never heard before and holographic windows I'd never seen raced in every direction, to the ends of the earth and above the clouds.

Ding. Ding. Ding. Diiiiing!

One sound swallowed another. The translucent holographic windows multiplied from one to five, from five to dozens, then to a hundred.

They were a wave. A mountain.

"Ah…!"

A gasp escaped me. Cold ran down my spine at the sight before me.

Hundreds. Perhaps thousands.

More holographic windows than I could count burst forth like fireworks. They all came from one being—the beginning and center of everything.

The Prophet.

I could hardly breathe. These weren't merely pieces of information. They were the countless lives he had devoured, the gravestones they had left behind.

Gravestones bearing nothing but names and levels.

And the Truthful Eye within me saw through the identity of the gravedigger who had built this vast cemetery of the dead. It stripped away the thick veil around him and revealed the truth.

Ding.

One final bell rang in my ears. The last piece of the puzzle fell into place.

This is…

At last, I understood what The Prophet truly was. How this cursed monster had hidden his identity for more than thirty years while doing everything he'd done.

Right. Now I get it.

I stared at The Prophet, still smiling. Then, with the breath I'd been holding, I spat out a single word.

"Doppelganger."

I saw his reaction clearly.

"…!"

The corners of his mouth, which had been curved like a half-moon, stiffened. The holographic window hovering above his head shone with a particularly gloomy light.

SYSTEM

Level 170 “The Final Abyss” Doppelganger

Doppelganger.

A harbinger of ill fortune, a being spoken of like a superstition.

Countless monsters of old myth had torn through the pages of legend and leaped into reality. Yet a doppelganger had never once appeared. Humanity had come to believe there were none among the enemies they had defeated, or those they had yet to face.

Not even in the horrifying Demon Realm. A doppelganger was nothing but an illusion born of fear, a mere superstition.

They were wrong.

The doppelganger had been there from the beginning. Everyone had mistaken its failure to reveal itself for its absence.

At least Jin Taekyung knew that better than anyone. He even knew when this incomprehensible being, which had devoured countless lives, had first slipped into their world.

“Michael Silbert. The Great Battle of Paris.”

His voice came out abruptly, hard as the cliff rock on either side of them. The monster’s smile, frozen for a moment, eased back into place.

“That’s right. On the very day you humans call Christmas, I met him and became part of this world.”

December 25, 2020.

The great battle that made a page in history—and made the name Michael Silbert known to all humanity.

As one layer of that day’s truth peeled away, Jin Taekyung swallowed hard. The Skeleton King clenched his teeth, while Magic Johnson stared at The Prophet—or rather, the doppelganger—in disbelief.

“That can’t be. The one that attacked Paris at the time was definitely…”

“A Dragon. More precisely, a hatchling less than three hundred years old. It was born a Dragon, so arrogance was in its nature. And it let its guard down, as young ones do. Of course, it was unexpected that a human would kill it, even so.”

The doppelganger had cut Johnson off. He went on.

“In the end, they were simply unlucky. The young Dragon, and the humans who miraculously survived their encounter with it.”

The Grand Mage, who had lived through the Great Cataclysm firsthand, couldn’t hold back a groan.

"…It was a lie, then. Michael Silbert made all of it up."

"Well, not all of it. A Dragon did attack Paris. And Michael did survive alone."

The doppelganger grinned.

"I knew the moment I saw him. Unlike the others, Michael was quick to understand his position. Before I'd killed even half of them, he was on his knees, begging me to spare him. He said he'd do anything if I let him live."

"…!"

"An interesting offer. I accepted. Then he killed the remaining humans himself."

Jin Taekyung suddenly remembered a line from the conversation he'd had with Michael Silbert just before the man met his end.

I was struggling to survive, too!

He'd sounded as though he were spitting blood.

He'd been telling the truth. Michael Silbert had struggled to survive. His desire to live was greater than anyone's, and he still had ambitions to fulfill.

And so a human and a monster had joined forces.

But it wasn't a shackle. It was a contract. Two monsters who differed in appearance but shared the same nature had made a deal to achieve their own goals.

But…

"What for?"

"What?"

"I asked what it was for. What was your real reason for wanting to live among people in this world?"

Jin Taekyung ground out the words. After a moment's silence, the doppelganger smiled.

"Well, I don't think now's the time to wait for my answer."

And at that moment—

Rumble.

A tremor swept through the canyon from far away.

Chapter 814

Crack. Rumble.

The ground shook. Clods of dirt and fragments of rock broke away from the towering cliffs and rained down overhead, one after another.

"…Damn it."

Magic Johnson muttered the words like a groan. The Skeleton King and hundreds of undead blocked the canyon's exit, crouching low as they stared into the darkness.

More precisely, at the countless enemies approaching from beyond it.

Fwoooosh.

I steadied my breathing and heightened my Qi Sense, sharpening my senses to take in everything around me.

The depth and force of the tremors traveling through the ground. The wind blowing from the west, and the smell it carried. And the sounds.

They were too far away for me to judge their exact number or strength, but I was certain of one thing.

They're not monsters.

That left only one possibility. The Doppelganger sensed my gaze and bared its bloodstained teeth in a grin.

"Humans are such strange creatures. They'll throw their lives away for a being they've never even seen, calling it a god. All it takes is a few solemn words, and they're weeping buckets."

"Fanatics…"

"I liked this land from the start. It was a good place to make plans and cover them up. Most of all, it was crawling with people willing to give their very souls to religion. It was astonishingly easy to win the faith of fools like that."

Squirm. Crack.

The cleanly severed stump of its wrist twitched. Through the gaps in its shattered armor, I could see fresh, pale flesh already growing over the dagger wound in its chest.

It wasn't a potion. It wasn't magic.

And yet, even now, its broken body was healing.

An unbelievable rate of recovery—obviously not human. The power of Regeneration, enough to make anyone suspicious.

But the fanatics who had been launching terrorist attacks around the world since before the Great Cataclysm would have seen it differently.

Perhaps they'd glimpsed the shadow of a god in the Doppelganger, who used mana and had the same red blood and flesh as they did.

"A miracle."

Its voice rang out, brimming with excitement. The Doppelganger stared at me with blazing eyes and continued.

"To them, I am not a monster but a miracle itself—the Prophet who will lead them to the promised land."

"…!"

"They'll fight until the very last one falls. For their god. And for me."

I didn't argue with the Doppelganger's confident claim.

It was the truth.

No matter what we did, a clash was inevitable.

The Doppelganger had planted its followers in this desert far earlier than I'd expected. The wave of fanatics that began there had already shaken the world through terrorism.

So even if I told them the truth about the Doppelganger, nothing would change.

If a few words were enough to make them see reason, they wouldn't be fanatics.

This was the work of a monster and a bunch of madmen. And right now, I was nothing but a heretic who had to be killed.

A heretic persecuting the great Prophet chosen by God.

"Then there's only one thing left to do."

I muttered evenly, staring at the Doppelganger. It understood what I meant, and the corners of its mouth curled upward.

"I'm looking forward to it."

"Yeah?"

Thud!

As I spoke, I thrust my dagger forward, piercing its heart.

Its limbs were bound, so it couldn't dodge. The Doppelganger merely frowned and sighed.

"Give it a rest. That hurts like hell."

Crack.

The severed muscles and shattered bones returned to their proper places. Bright red blood filled the gaps, and smooth skin, like a child's, grew over it.

It healed at a staggering speed, as if a video were playing in fast-forward.

Even the great shards of bone that had pierced its limbs and pinned it deep into the cliff shifted slightly, pushed by the flesh and bone growing around them.

The countless Level windows I'd seen with the **Truthful Eye**—and could still see now—meant far more than they appeared to.

Other lives.

They were fuel, but they were also the lives of the victims the Doppelganger had devoured.

Like an arcade game character that came back to life whenever you fed it a coin, the bastard could keep reviving.

But it's not truly immortal.

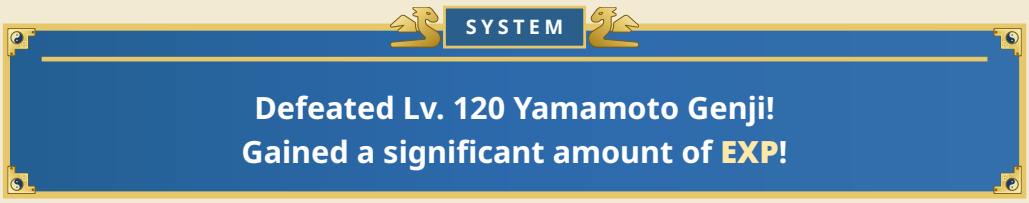
I twisted the dagger still in my hand. Heat surged from my dantian, raced through my acupoints, and flowed into the blade.

Thud—boom!

Scorching Yang Qi poured through the dagger buried deep in its chest and exploded inside the Doppelganger.

Its heart had already been pierced once, yet it had recovered as if nothing could kill it. Now the heart was crushed completely, and the clear bell I'd been waiting for rang in my ear.

Ding.



"…!"

One life faded, and a new one took its place.

The Doppelganger was still grinning. Behind its melting skin, another unfamiliar face was ready to emerge.

"Imagine that. Jin Taekyung killed Genji. Japan's going to lose its mind when they hear about this."

"Shut your mouth."

A low nose bridge. Crooked teeth visible inside its mouth.

Judging by features distinctive even among East Asians, this had to be a Hunter from J1—one of the team thought to have been wiped out apart from Yamamoto Genji.

"Come to think of it, I forgot to introduce myself. Nice to meet you. I'm Hiroshi Inoue. I spent my childhood in Nagasaki, then moved to Tokyo…"

I grabbed it by the throat and twisted hard.

Its neck bones shattered under my grip, and its head bent at a grotesque angle.

Ding. Another bell rang, and the twisted head straightened. The face, smiling coyly, belonged to a woman I'd never seen before.

"Oh, did you know? This woman was the lover of the man you just killed. Looks like they were planning to get married this year."

"…!"

My hand stopped dead, as if someone had hit a pause button. The Doppelganger whistled, clearly enjoying itself.

"Wow. So passionate. Humans really are amazing when it comes to things like this. We could learn a thing or two."

"…You."

"Ah, sorry. I apologize if that made you uncomfortable. But what can I do? It's my ability."

I clenched my teeth.

The Doppelganger hadn't just absorbed its victims' appearances. It could reproduce their abilities exactly as they'd had them in life—and it had their memories, too.

Those memories, spilling from its mouth, dug into my chest like an awl and made me hesitate.

Crack.

Blood seeped between my clenched teeth.

Beyond the canyon, the tremors had grown stronger, and I could feel a fierce killing intent. In front of me, a monster that came back no matter how many times I killed it was smiling faintly.

"Jin!"

Magic Johnson's urgent shout struck my eardrums. The smile on the Doppelganger's face deepened.

"This is your last chance."

"What?"

"Right now is your last chance to run and survive."

"…!"

Whoosh.

The cool desert wind brushed my face. It felt as if I'd been doused in cold water.

The Doppelganger shrugged at me as I stood frozen like a statue.

"I understand. It'd hurt your pride. You'd be embarrassed. But if you die here like the rest of those humans, would that be a pointless death—or a noble sacrifice by a hero?"

"…That's…"

"You have to look at the bigger picture. You're the World Hunter Federation's Alliance Leader. The one and only light and hope who can save this world, like someone from the past. Aren't you?"

Its gentle voice tickled my ear, like a snake coaxing me to steal and eat the forbidden apple.

The Doppelganger's low whisper wound softly around my whole body.

"Run. And survive."

Rumble.

The canyon shook. The footsteps of countless fanatics—and the hooves of the camels they rode—were approaching from the darkness beyond.

"Think of your family and friends. Can you even imagine how much sorrow and pain they'll suffer because of your death?"

"…Sorrow and pain?"

"That's right. You've been through it yourself."

My lips moved without a sound.

Sorrow and pain over someone's death. Yeah, I'd been through it. It had shaken me so badly I'd felt close to falling apart.

"No one will blame you. Even I respect everything you've done. So even now…"

The eyes of the nameless woman—or rather, the Doppelganger—sparkled.

"Run."

"Allahu Akbar!"[3237]

The mighty roar of countless voices merging into one rang across the darkening desert.

Brilliant light shimmered around Magic Johnson, while hundreds of undead stared with dimly glowing eyes at the waves of fanatics surging toward them.

And I…

Let go of the Doppelganger's neck.

Step.

I took a step back and saw it smiling at me. It spoke gently, as if to a child.

"Good. You made the right choice."

I found myself muttering.

"Is this the best option?"

"It has to be."

"Good. Then I'm glad."

I nodded, then murmured under my breath.

"Open. Summon."

"Hm?"

Shhk!

As it asked its empty question, the Doppelganger's head flew into the air.

A new face rose onto its shoulders as if someone had turned a page, and blinked.

The heat blazing around **White Flame**'s spearhead cast a reddish glow in its eyes.

"What the fuck are you, some Ditto from a failed link trade? Quit trying to pull that crap on me."

Only then did the Doppelganger understand what had happened. It sighed.

"You crazy bastard…"

[3237] *Allahu Akbar* is an Arabic phrase meaning "God is greatest."

"Got anything more original? I've heard that one so many times I'm sick of it."

"Why are you doing this?"

"That's what I want to ask you."

"What?"

"You started spouting nonsense from the get-go, and I wondered what the hell was going on. But the more I listened, the more curious I got. You're the first monster I've ever seen telling a human to run. For a second, I almost called you Mom, you son of a bitch."

"…"

"What the hell are you? You're trying so hard not to get caught, but you keep giving yourself away. So I know you're stupid—but what do you actually want?"

A brief silence followed. The Doppelganger stared at me without a word, then furrowed its brow.

"Damn it. This has gone to shit. Why are you so reckless? You want to be remembered by history as a hero who made a noble sacrifice?"

"Quit talking out of your ass and answer me. My dream is to be the head of a longevity village."

"Then why the hell…!"

Scree!

A cry rang out from the sky, swallowing the Doppelganger's unfinished words.

It naturally looked up at the sky, and its eyes suddenly widened.

"…What's that?"

I already knew what the Doppelganger was seeing.

Before the forces split up, I'd used Sound Transmission to give the Skeleton King direct orders.

"They're a little late, but they made it just in time."

Screee!

Dozens of eagles and griffins glided over the canyon with their wings spread wide.

On the backs of the enormous flying beasts, I could see the Hunters who should have gone east.

Chapter 815

Whoooosh.

Cold night wind swept over Choi Minwoo. He brushed back his windblown hair and looked down at the canyon rushing closer.

There it is.

The spearhead's cold gleam was unmistakable even in the deep darkness.

Choi had collected countless fine weapons and artifacts over the years, but the strength and sharpness of the spear named White Flame still amazed him.

Though not as much as its owner.

He thought of Jin Taekyung.

When they first met, Choi could never have imagined that the young man his age who'd joined a raid as a porter would stand above every Hunter in the world less than a year later.

But Jin Taekyung had made the unimaginable real.

He had prevented countless disasters and grown astonishingly through every ordeal. The boldness and courage he showed in a crisis kept surpassing even Choi's expectations—and Choi had watched him more closely than anyone.

Just like today.

I could tell something was different from usual…but Mr. Jin keeps getting another step ahead of us.

When the Skeleton King's undead relayed what was happening, Choi had felt surprised and a little hurt. Before long, though, those feelings had turned to joy.

Jin had solved a problem no one else could. That was proof he'd grown yet again.

With him, we can win.

Jin Taekyung was the commander in chief leading them all, the general directing the battle, and the vanguard who charged toward the enemy ahead of everyone else.

How could Choi not trust him? How could he not love him?

No matter how many obstacles and dangers lay along Jin's path, that would never change.

There are a lot of them.

Choi gazed down calmly.

Hundreds of meters[3238] below, a black mass of enemies poured into the canyon like a wave.

Too many to count.

Their footsteps shook the earth, and their shouts rang out from every direction.

[3238] Hundreds of meters is roughly hundreds to thousands of feet; 100 m is about 328 ft.

"Allahu Akbar!"[3239]

"Brothers and sisters, charge! To the promised land!"

"God's salvation awaits us!"

The fanatics who'd hidden from the eyes of the world were crying out. Ironically, those calling for God's salvation held weapons that brought blood and death.

They're not people like us. They're just enemies we have to bring down.

Choi repeated the thought to himself like a vow. No—every Hunter looking down at them felt the same way.

They'd already seen it. They'd learned it the hard way.

Humans could be more good—or more evil—than any other living creature. Monsters weren't the only things that threatened this world.

Before Demon King Asmodeus descended, those who had brought about countless wars and deaths had been human, too. Humanity had suffered at their hands and learned a lesson it must never forget.

There are monsters with red blood, too.

And the Hunters gathered here existed for one reason. Their sole duty was to hunt those monsters.

Shing.

Blades appeared here and there, their edges glinting coldly.

The Hunters were visibly more exhausted than usual after their battle against the monster horde, but the determination in their eyes was stronger than ever.

Fwoooosh!

The wind grew fiercer. Hearts pounded faster.

Dozens of eagles and griffins angled their enormous wings and plunged toward the ground.

The fanatics' shouts, distant as an echo a moment ago, now thundered in everyone's ears.

"Fight to the last! Don't fall back!"

Choi swallowed. The wind stung his skin. The fanatics surged into the canyon, radiating a madness that seemed almost tangible.

A towering Grand Mage and the Skeleton King, with hundreds of undead at his command, stood in their way. Not one of the fanatics was afraid.

To them, this was a holy war. Even if they died, they would stand beside God as holy martyrs.

These warriors of God had already experienced the miracle of awakening. They kicked off their camels and shot forward at blinding speed.

Three hundred meters.[3240] One hundred.[3241] Fifty.[3242]

[3239] *Allahu Akbar* is Arabic for "God is greatest."

[3240] 300 m is about 984 ft.

The distance vanished.

And then…

Impact.

Boom! Kaa-boooom!

“Graaagh!”

Flames devoured the darkness.

The vanguard took a direct hit from Magic Johnson’s attack magic and went up in flames, screaming. Other fanatics instantly filled the gap left by the dead and charged the undead without hesitation.

Crunch, craaack!

The canyon wasn’t absurdly narrow, but it wasn’t wide, either. Yet the fanatics the Doppelganger had cultivated over many years broke through the undead battle line at once.

In their hearts and minds, they might already have been monsters. But they were fundamentally different from actual monsters.

They were as strong and clever as any Hunter. Above all, they had two excellent commanders.

“Fallen demons! Wipe them all out!”

“Inshallah.”[3243]

One man rampaged at the front, shouting roughly. An old man watched the battlefield with a composed expression from the rear.

The two stood out even amid the chaos. The moment Choi spotted them, he instinctively grasped how powerful they were.

S-rank Hunters—or should I call them fanatics?

They were beyond what he could handle now.

Strangely, he wasn’t afraid.

The next moment, the old man looked up, and their eyes met. Choi’s resolve didn’t waver.

Shhk. Slice!

The strike came like a flash of light.

A streak of aura shot from the old man’s waist and cleanly severed the neck of Choi’s griffin. The huge flying monster went limp and tipped to one side.

Fwoosh. Rattle!

The wind turned violent, and Choi was thrown about.

But he didn’t panic. Their dive had become a fall, yet for some reason, he found himself smiling.

[3241] 100 m is about 328 ft.

[3242] 50 m is about 164 ft.

[3243] *Inshallah* is Arabic for “God willing.”

The screams of the other Hunters clinging to the griffin's spine didn't matter. Neither did the way they stared at him as though he'd lost his mind.

I don't regret any of the choices I've made. I'll just fight as hard as I can.

His mind was calm. The sword in his hand felt as light as a feather. Today, he felt he could do anything.

The ground rushed closer, and the shout of a fanatic he didn't know struck his ears.

"For the great God, for the Prophet!"

Choi laughed aloud. Then he spoke.

"For our Alliance Leader."

His voice was low but powerful. It was the signal.

Papat!

Choi Minwoo—and all the Hunters—kicked off the body of the griffin plummeting straight toward the ground and soared away.

Tap.

Choi landed first. The sword in his hand blurred.

Whoosh! Chaaash!

A sharp wind rose from the blade, slicing through the limbs of fanatics rushing him from every side.

A streak of light shot between the bodies collapsing in sprays of blood.

Whoosh—bang!

Choi raised his sword in time to block it, but that was all he could do.

The force drove him back several steps. A low voice reached his ears.

"I thought I recognized that face. Now I know—you're Sky's blood."

The Arab man approached with a sword wrapped in aura, his eyes full of menace.

Amid the chaos, Choi spoke in his heart to someone he couldn't see.

I don't know how long I—or we—can hold out.

But he knew one thing better than anyone.

He had to fight. He couldn't fall before the enemy did.

Even if that enemy was far stronger than him.

Swish.

Choi pointed his sword at the man. The **Hero's Sword**, imbued with brilliant aura, shone brightly.

The eight hundred or so Hunters who'd dropped from the sky gathered around its light as it spread through the darkness.

"Damn heretics. I'll send you all to hell."

The man vanished from sight, a vicious smile on his face. A sword strike flashed out at the same instant and grazed Choi's neck as he instinctively ducked.

The Skeleton King, who'd been holding off the fanatics swarming from all sides, shot toward the man.

Boom!

Countless roars and screams swept through the canyon. The ground heaved, and the solid bedrock split apart.

The bloodshed and shock of a battle unlike any the canyon had seen in centuries reached the cliffs on either side—even the canyon's center, dozens of meters[3244] beyond its entrance.

And those tiny cracks helped, if only a little, to free someone who should never have escaped.

Thud-thud. Bang!

A bone shard as long as a spear and thicker than one blasted outward. At the same time, new flesh and blood welled up from the severed ends of countless shattered limbs.

Slide. Crack.

Recovery so fast it was impossible to believe, even seeing it firsthand.

No—Regeneration.

The Doppelganger completed its one hundred and forty-fifth resurrection and grinned, baring bloodstained teeth.

"Oh. We're only getting started, and you're tired already?"

Thwack!

A streak of light pierced the space between its eyes instead of answering. The young man holding the spear moved his dry, cracked lips.

"No. I think I've got a little more in me now."

And at that moment—

Ding.

A bell rang out clearly, audible to one person alone.

Right after reaching the Supreme Peak realm, I'd joined the ranks of the superhuman. No one could deny that.

But even superhumans were still human.

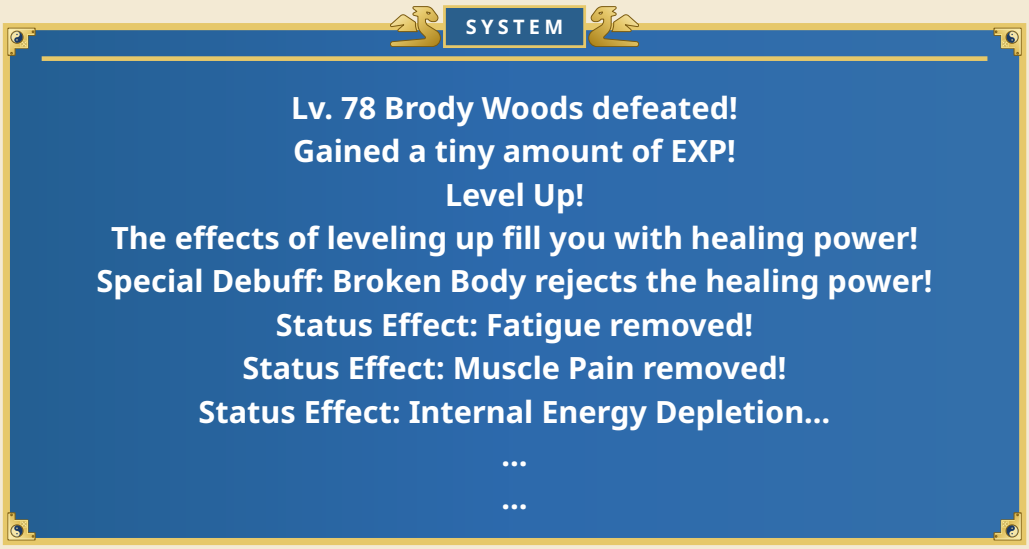
They felt pain when they were hurt, tensed up when they faced someone strong, and eventually grew tired if they kept moving.

I was one of them.

Except for one thing.

Ding.

[3244] One dozen meters is 12 m, about 39 ft.



As System messages appeared one after another, my fading vision cleared.

I felt the fatigue melt away and my internal energy return. I muttered a name.

“Brody Woods. Brody Woods...”

A name I had to remember for the rest of my life. Brody was a hero who’d saved me when I was nearing my limit.

The same went for every one of those victims who’d died twice.

With that in mind...

“Die.”

Slice.

The Doppelganger was staggering to its feet when my spearhead swept through it. Its upper body slid away at an angle.

And at the same time, the sight I’d grown sick of seeing played out before my eyes once again.

Slither.

Blood and flesh welled up at a terrifying speed. The Doppelganger rose whole, looking more relaxed than ever.

“That’s enough. You must be close to your limit by now.”

“Nope. I’m doing fine.”

Thrust!

“You can’t have much left. No need to bluff.”

“I told you, I’m fine.”

Thud, splatter!

“This really is the last—”

“Hey.”

Slice!

Resurrected yet again, the Doppelganger muttered, “What kind of fucking bastard are you...?”

Chapter 816

What the hell was going on?

The Doppelganger couldn't help being baffled. Dying the moment it came back to life was one thing. It had even expected to put up little resistance.

Its limbs had been bound, and Jin Taekyung was stronger than any human it had ever seen.

But there was one thing it couldn't understand.

What is this?

He wasn't getting tired. He just wasn't.

More precisely, whenever he seemed to be tiring, he was suddenly fine again. Even the Doppelganger, sick to death of experiencing death, was starting to curse.

"What kind of fucking bastard is this…?"

Slice!

Before it could finish, a flash of light. A spearhead, driven with precise force and speed, cut across its Adam's apple.

One life faded, and another life and its memories—absorbed long ago—filled the empty space.

What kind of bullshit is this?

The Doppelganger came back to life after a brief moment of pain, its eyelids twitching. A spearhead was already flying toward it.

Whoosh!

A lightning-fast strike.

But this time, the Doppelganger had no intention of going down so easily.

A moment ago, it had been a middling B-rank Hunter. With this resurrection, it was a genuine A-rank Hunter.

One of the top twenty rankers in France, no less.

Jean the Swift.

Recalling the nickname from the memories it had absorbed, the Doppelganger stepped onto the ground with feet that felt unusually light.

Swish.

A breeze skimmed past its chest by a hair's breadth.

Its form wavered like a heat haze, then appeared several meters[3245] back. A relaxed smile spread across its lips. It had dodged without difficulty.

"From here on, things won't be so ea—"

Shwhack! Thunk!

[3245] One meter is about 3.28 ft; several meters is roughly several yards.

A streak of Finger Qi pierced the space between its eyes. Having died without putting up a fight after all, the Doppelganger blinked as it came back to life.

Huh? That's not right.

It hadn't even seen what hit it. At least Jin Taekyung had stopped attacking for a moment, for some reason.

"Huh? What was that just now?"

At the sight of him asking in apparent surprise, the Doppelganger felt sure of itself.

Of course. That last hit must've been pure luck.

From its perspective, the conclusion was only natural.

The Hunter whose life it had just used had ranked among the best in his country. An assassin-type Hunter whose speed had earned him the name Jean the Swift. If he'd decided to dodge from the start, even Michael Silbert would have found him a nuisance.

No matter how special Jin Taekyung is, he can't be that far above Michael Silbert.

But the Doppelganger had no idea what Jin Taekyung's question had really meant.

Jean Pierre? Who's this guy, and why is he worth so much EXP?

He'd never heard the name. The Hunter world might be small, but he couldn't know every foreign Hunter by name unless they were famous worldwide.

Anyway, thank you. Rest in peace.

Jin Taekyung offered his thanks and condolences to the Hunter who'd been absorbed, then raised his lowered spearhead.

That was enough respect for the dead. What he needed to do next was already clear.

Before even more people were sacrificed, he had to copy the EXP—no, completely erase the Doppelganger.

"No time to waste. Let's get one more death in."

Thrust! Crack!

"Gah…!"

With a final cry, another flame of life went out.

The Doppelganger had died more than two hundred times in less than ten minutes. Unease began to show in its eyes.

This can't go on. I underestimated him.

The Doppelganger had greedily devoured countless lives. For more than thirty years, it had absorbed human souls, memories, and powers across the world, becoming something close to immortal.

Its ability was unique even among the countless kinds of monsters in the Demon Realm.

But the Doppelganger knew exactly where its limits lay.

I'm not completely immortal, and I can't combine the powers I've absorbed into one.

A fire dies when it runs out of wood. Thousands of different fragments could be joined together, but they could never become a single whole.

It was an extraordinary ability. But not when measured against the rare few born to wield absolute power.

Like the one who had sent it to this world.

Until every part of the plan is complete, I must never come face-to-face with the target.

Whump!

Its vision went black. Another death—how many now?—cut off the voice echoing in its mind.

Cough.

The Doppelganger came back to life in pain, regret passing over its face.

I should never have gotten close to him.

The reason for its failure was clear.

For more than thirty years, the Doppelganger had enjoyed a freedom it had never known before. After Cheon Taemin disappeared, it had manipulated the world from the shadows.

That freedom and power had gone to its head.

In the Demon Realm, it had been bound to someone else. Here, it was a king in all but name, able to accomplish anything it set its mind to.

The more arrogant the Doppelganger became, the less weight it gave to its orders—and the heavier its own complacency grew.

Michael Silbert?

Even he was only a servant and a tool. His obedience was commendable enough, but when the time came, he would be discarded like any piece that had served its purpose.

The plan had taken a long time to prepare. Now it was only one step from completion.

And yet…

Damn it.

Slice.

Something hot cut across its chest. Pain it still couldn’t get used to seized its whole body.

Hoo.

As death gave way to life again, the Doppelganger let out the breath that had been cut short.

The moment it opened its eyes, someone’s fist filled its vision.

Thwack.

Its vision swam. Only when it came to again did it realize its head had been smashed apart.

It took an involuntary step back and slipped on the brain matter it had spilled moments earlier.

“Internal energy’s wasted on a bastard like you.”

Jin Taekyung’s voice reached its ears. He sounded so calm it was chilling, and the chill stole the Doppelganger’s breath.

A foot slammed down on its chest with tremendous weight and took what little breath remained.

Crack! Crunch! Splatter!

Darkness. Light. Darkness again, without pause.

In fractions of a single second, the Doppelganger died and came back to life several times.

Even freed from its restraints, it fared no better. If anything, a wider variety of deaths and agonies awaited it.

Why? Why the hell?!

It screamed its anger and regret in silence.

Only now did it truly understand its master’s command not to meet the target before the plan was complete.

This man… is different.

He was unlike any human it had absorbed over the years, or any it had watched from afar, licking its lips while taking care not to draw attention.

No. He didn’t seem human at all.

Just like Cheon Taemin.

Whoom! Boom!

With a heavy rush of air, an open palm struck its chest. The force shattered its bones, and the heat within the blow burned its organs.

Cough.

The Doppelganger spat out dead blood and looked at Jin Taekyung through dimming eyes.

Jin’s face blurred as its vision darkened, but the powerful aura pouring from his body was clearer than anything else in the world.

“The C-Chosen One…”

The words slipped out like a groan. Its head drooped limply.

Jin Taekyung’s fist shot toward it like a mace to deliver another death—then touched its forehead as lightly as a blade of grass.

Tap. Fwoosh!

The wind swept around them, unable to keep up with the speed of his punch. Jin Taekyung’s cold gaze settled on the Doppelganger’s new face.

“What did you just say?”

“…!”

The Doppelganger swallowed. It had let the words slip without meaning to. Its consciousness had grown hazy through the endless deaths and resurrections of those few moments.

“I didn’t say anything…”

“Really?”

Grab. Crack!

Before it could finish, its vision went black.

It had lost count of its deaths. Less than half the countless lives that had filled its body remained.

The Doppelganger opened its eyes amid bedrock shattered along with its skull. Regret had given way to fear.

Fear of death itself.

At this rate… I’ll be erased.

Its life was not infinite. To survive, it had absorbed the life force of others and burned it like firewood, just as its kin had once done.

And they, too, were erased forever.

There had been a time when the Doppelgangers held sway over the Demon Realm. But after long years and a brutal purge, it alone had survived out of hundreds of its kind.

That was why “Doppelganger” had become the name of a single being—and why it was called “The Final Abyss.”

I can’t—I can’t be erased. I have to survive!

The Doppelganger gritted its teeth and opened its eyes. New life force and mana filled its body, along with the abilities of the human it had absorbed.

Vrrrrm.

Mana gathered around its fist, coating it in a faint aura. The Doppelganger sprang to its feet and drove a punch toward Jin Taekyung’s face.

Whoosh!

The thunderous rush of air came a moment later. A hard, thick palm blocked its fist.

No—it squeezed it.

Crack.

“…!”

Pain nearly wiped its mind blank.

Its fist had been crushed like tofu. And once again, there was no escaping death.

“Hey, what are you doing?”

Whoom! Boom!

The world turned upside down. Its consciousness returned with a crash loud enough to burst its eardrums.

The Doppelganger revived in the center of a small crater and immediately kicked off the ground.

Away from Jin Taekyung.

I'll survive. Somehow!

It had long since forgotten shame. Jin Taekyung was the "Chosen One" its master had spoken of.

The Doppelganger drew out every bit of power this new life had given it and launched itself away.

Pop!

Its blurred form shot through the air.

Or tried to.

As it took its second step, a streak of light flashed toward it.

Slice!

Its headless body slammed into the ground. Several meters[3246] away, the Doppelganger came back to life, only for a lightning-fast strike to cleave down over its head.

Fwoosh!

A fountain of blood burst from its body, split in two.

Jin Taekyung didn't stop. His heated spearhead cut through the air again and again.

Shh-shh-shhk!

A flash of light cut across its tilting body. Its limbs, chopped into dozens of pieces, hit the ground—and immediately began to grow back at a terrifying speed.

"Gyaaaah!"

The Doppelganger roared as it revived amid that gruesome death. Pain still lingered, gnawing at its senses like insects.

If Jin Taekyung had just used up a considerable amount of internal energy with that last strike, the Doppelganger had to sacrifice a dozen or more lives.

Now it understood. To escape Jin Taekyung, it would have to spend even the lives it had been saving.

Fwooooo.

Vast mana poured over both its hands. Looking at a face he seemed to recognize, Jin Taekyung muttered like a groan:

"Siegfried Bassmann?"

[3246] One meter is about 3.28 ft; several meters is roughly several yards.

Chapter 817

The Doppelganger's new face was all too familiar to Jin Taekyung.

He'd seen it in person only once, shriveled like a mummy. But while investigating Michael Silbert, he'd seen that same face in photographs so many times he was sick of it.

And then there was…

Whoooosh.

That immense magical power, so palpable he could almost reach out and touch it.

He didn't need to check the Level window to know the answer.

"Siegfried Bassmann?"

At Jin Taekyung's muttered question, the Doppelganger snapped its fingers instead of answering.

Crackle.

White light flashed.

The faint current running along its finger became dozens of lightning bolts and came crashing down. It took only an instant.

Zzap!

Blinding light filled Jin Taekyung's vision.

His eyes closed before he knew it, but he could still feel the tremendous current through the rock surrounding him, the air, and the ground. Through everything.

Boom!

The hard rock and earth beneath him split in a spiderweb of cracks.

Jin Taekyung kicked off the ground and shot upward, thrusting out a palm. The heat of Flame Divine Palm burned through the lightning as it surged forward.

KABOOOOOM!

A tremendous blast shook the canyon.

But Jin Taekyung sharpened his sight and caught everything that happened in that brief moment.

The rising flames. The acrid smoke.

And the Doppelganger vanishing like a ghost just before it all erupted.

Blink.

Teleport and Warp were spells for crossing long distances. Blink was short-range movement: disappearing for an instant, just as its name suggested.

Its range was limited. Jin Taekyung's senses and vision, on the other hand, covered the entire canyon.

There.

He couldn't see it. But he could feel it.

Jin Taekyung drew a breath. He trusted his senses and his abilities.

Channeling internal energy through his toes, he stepped on empty air and shot toward the Doppelganger beyond the drifting embers and acrid smoke.

Whoosh! Boom!

The air burst around him, unable to withstand his speed. Smoke and embers scattered as if blown apart, and his vision cleared.

At the end of his path, having become a streak of flame, he found the Doppelganger fleeing toward the followers who could help it.

"…!"

A chill prickled down its back. The Doppelganger turned instinctively, its eyes widening.

In a world that seemed to slow around it, Jin Taekyung was already right in front of it, filling its vision.

How the hell?

Less than a second had passed.

Yet Jin Taekyung had found where Blink had taken it and crossed the dozen or so meters[3247] between them.

You've got to be fucking kidding me…!

The Doppelganger swallowed the curse rising to its lips.

No. It hadn't even had time to curse.

Waste a moment, and it could lose the Grand Mage's power forever—an asset far more precious than all the other lives it had discarded.

Shwaa!

A reddish-hot spearhead tore through the wind. The killing intent that accompanied it was cold enough to freeze the Doppelganger in place.

But the mana and abilities it possessed at that moment belonged to one of only three Grand Mages in the world.

Blin—k!

Fwoosh, boom!

Flames erupted along the spearhead and devoured the empty air.

The Doppelganger appeared a dozen or so meters[3248] away and felt a chill run down its spine.

Because it had barely escaped?

No.

Because a pair of eyes was staring straight at it.

Jin Taekyung.

[3247] A dozen or so meters is approximately 12 m (39 ft).

[3248] A dozen or so meters is approximately 12 m (39 ft).

Their gazes had only met, but its heart sank. An instinct honed over centuries of struggle whispered to it.

Run.

If it didn't want that beast to tear out the back of its neck, it couldn't let its guard down for a moment.

The Doppelganger cast Blink again without pausing. In the next instant, it knew its instinct had been right.

Whoosh! Slice!

It opened its eyes in a new space and let out the breath it had been holding.

The back of its armor, long since stripped of its original shape and purpose, was hot from the heat that had grazed it.

He cut me. He's fast enough to keep up with Blink.

It had escaped by a hair.

A shiver ran through it. Of all the humans it had absorbed or encountered in passing, none had been a monster like this.

Except for the one person it feared—and had deliberately avoided for that reason.

Cheon Taemin.

The savior of humanity.

The only Adversary to face the Demon King Asmodeus with the body and mind of a frail human. A divine man.

The Doppelganger neither denied its fear of Cheon Taemin nor felt ashamed of it.

He was no being it could call "a mere human."

That was why, even after absorbing Siegfried Bassmann years ago and learning of Cheon Taemin's condition, it had never dared to go after him.

But the Doppelganger had never imagined it could feel this much fear of any human other than Cheon Taemin.

Blink, Blink, Blink!

Hesitate, and it might face permanent Erasure.

Desperate, the Doppelganger leaped through space again and again.

Each time its form vanished as if rubbed away by an eraser, it drew closer to the canyon exit, where a fierce battle was underway.

The hunter pursuing it drew closer, too.

Whsssh!

A sharp whistle cut through the air.

A dozen or so daggers flashed toward the Doppelganger's entire body. The attack had been timed and aimed so precisely that it had no chance to cast Blink.

With no other choice, the Doppelganger gritted its teeth and spread both hands.

Vrrrrm, crack!

Its mana shield shattered before it had fully formed. The daggers ricocheted away and buried themselves in the cliffs and ground on either side.

But in the brief time it took to block them, Jin Taekyung had reached it.

“Got you.”

“…!”

Crack!

The Doppelganger had no time to react.

Its mouth fell open as tremendous pain shot through its wrist.

Siegfried Bassmann had been a great Grand Mage in life, but Jin Taekyung’s terrifying strength couldn’t be stopped by any magic in his memories.

Crreeeak!

“Gyaaaah!”

The scream tore from the Doppelganger’s lips.

Jin Taekyung’s grip alone crushed flesh and muscle and splintered bone.

Its vision went white. The sky and ground tilted.

I’m being flipped over. No—I’m going to die.

The Doppelganger knew it instinctively.

After this terrifying feeling of weightlessness would come the impact. Its whole body would be crushed against the ground.

No!

Siegfried Bassmann was the most precious of all the lives it had absorbed.

Hunting a publicly known S-rank Hunter was difficult enough. A Grand Mage was an especially valuable prize, granting it the versatile power of magic.

If I lose magic, I’m finished. I’d rather…!

Fear sent its thoughts racing. Its decision was immediate.

Whoooom!

As it hurtled toward the ground, the Doppelganger drew up mana with all its strength.

Blink!

Flash.

The world slowed.

Space warped by mana swallowed its body. But this time, the amount of mana was different—and so was the spell’s stability.

The Doppelganger fixed its gaze on the battlefield hundreds of meters[3249] away, far beyond Blink’s normal range.

I have to make it.

This crossed a forbidden limit of spatial magic.

[3249] Hundreds of meters is roughly 200–900 m (660–3,000 ft).

But it was better than dying here. The fanatics who worshiped it like a god were there, followers it had spent decades cultivating.

Crreeeak!

Bone and flesh twisted along with space.

The pain felt as though an invisible hand were squeezing its heart until it burst. None of that mattered.

Jin Taekyung.

If it could get out of this monstrous human's grasp…

If it could escape under its followers' protection and carry out the plan it had prepared for so long…

Goodbye. See you next time.

The Doppelganger grinned, baring blood-soaked teeth.

Grrk, whoooosh!

Mana whipped around it like a storm, and warped space swallowed it whole.

Its vision went black. Then new light, noise, and faces washed over it in waves.

Boom! KABOOOOOM!

Shing! Krrrrk!

"Gah!"

"Warriors of God, do not fear death!"

"Go fuck yourselves, you insane fanatics!"

Blasts and screams erupted on every side. Shouts from both sides battered its ruptured eardrums.

But all that mattered to the Doppelganger was that the faces in its blurred vision belonged to its followers.

"W-wait!"

"Prophet!"

Fanatics in turbans spotted it and gathered around. The Doppelganger spat up blood mixed with bits of its entrails, then laughed aloud.

"Cough. Heh-heh…"

Pain?

That was fine. It would recover soon.

Bones throughout its body were shattered, and the left arm Jin Taekyung had grabbed had been torn off at the shoulder. What mattered was that Blink had worked beyond its limits.

An ordinary human would have died.

It had been lucky.

The spell had succeeded because Siegfried Bassmann was a Grand Mage. It had survived the injuries because it was a Doppelganger.

Slide. Crack.

Pale flesh, soft as a child's, slowly grew from the stump of its severed arm. Torn muscles joined, and white bone grew back.

Its recovery was incomparably slower than before. The Doppelganger clicked its tongue bitterly.

Damn it.

The countless lives it had absorbed were running low.

By the time it escaped this place entirely, it might have only a handful left.

But that doesn't matter. I have others willing to die for me.

A sea of fanatics surrounded it.

Smiling to itself, the Doppelganger staggered to its feet.

Fierce fighting raged around the canyon exit, but the rear position it had reached with Blink was peaceful. Plenty of troops remained there.

Including the core force it had taken such care to raise.

"Amir."

At the Doppelganger's low voice, the surrounding fanatics stepped aside.

An old man carrying a staff approached and knelt before it.

"I have been waiting for you, great Prophet."

Wonder filled his face and voice.

The Doppelganger looked down at him with all the authority befitting a prophet.

"God has led me elsewhere, so I must leave ahead of you. Hold back Jin Taekyung and the other heretics with all your strength."

God and Prophet were names that commanded absolute obedience.

But Amir asked again, looking bewildered.

"Jin Taekyung?"

"Why? Are you afraid of him?"

"No. But… hadn't you already subdued him, Prophet?"

The Doppelganger frowned.

"What do you mean? You couldn't have seen what happened."

"Yes. But you personally subdued him and brought him here."

"What?"

The Doppelganger blinked, unable to make sense of it.

Behind it, Jin Taekyung lay facedown as if dead. His eyes slowly opened.

"Uh, fuck. Where the hell am I now?"

"…!"

Chapter 818

“Uh, shit. Where the hell am I now?”

“…!”

The moment Jin Taekyung’s voice reached its ears, the Doppelganger froze like a statue. Two questions sprang to mind.

Why is he here?

Magic manifested according to the caster’s will alone.

And the Doppelganger had, of course, cast Blink on itself alone.

Even a full-blown psychopath with a mind that had spun around thirty-five times wouldn’t do something insane like cast a dangerous movement spell alongside Jin Taekyung—a man who could break the Doppelganger’s neck thirty-six times in the blink of an eye.

There was only one answer.

He interfered with my Blink spell… against my will.

Mana interference.

A theory the scholarly Grand Mage Siegfried Bassmann had developed after years of research surfaced among the memories the Doppelganger had absorbed.

The Doppelganger felt a chill sweep through its entire body. As it watched Jin Taekyung stagger to his feet, a second unanswered question lingered in its eyes.

How? How did he survive?

It could set the mana interference aside. The man was a monster, after all.

Absurd as it was—utterly absurd—perhaps a close-combat Hunter really did possess mana control surpassing even a Grand Mage’s.

But that Blink had been an outrageously dangerous attempt. The Doppelganger itself had nearly been torn apart for breaking the taboo and had sacrificed dozens of lives to heal. What more was there to say?

And yet…

“Ugh, my body’s all numb.”

Hearing Jin Taekyung mumble, the Doppelganger’s mind went hazy for a moment.

Numb? He’s numb?

It was impossible. The Doppelganger felt betrayed. Even if Jin Taekyung were an ogre, shouldn’t he at least have lost an arm or a leg or two, out of basic decency?

His body isn’t made of steel. So how?

The Doppelganger had no idea that Jin Taekyung’s physique—once called the Heavenly Martial Physique in Murim—had long since surpassed its limits, enough to withstand even a Blink spell that broke the taboo.

But it could grasp one truth without knowing why.

Jin Taekyung is weaker now than he's ever been.

The shock set off a long, tangled train of thought. In reality, only a few seconds passed.

And at the end of the suffocating silence pressing down on everything came the Doppelganger's shout, ringing out like a scream.

"Stop him!"

"…!"

"…!"

The silence shattered. At the same time, the world that had momentarily stopped began moving again. The fanatics, who had been staring blankly back and forth between Jin Taekyung and their great Prophet in that slowed-down moment, sprang into action.

"Inshallah!"[3250]

"God is great!"

Whoosh! Fwooooooosh!

Shouts and the whistle of weapons rang out on every side. Looking at the countless flashes hurtling toward him, Jin Taekyung suddenly opened his mouth.

No—he let it all out.

"Ugh. Bwaaaaaagh!"

Vomit sprayed into the air before a drop of blood did.

The price of hitching a ride on Blink was a hellish bout of motion sickness.

I'd tried to hold it in. I'd thought I could.

But life doesn't always go the way you want.

"Bwaaaagh!"

Fuck. I'd been about to say something cool.

Vomit came pouring out instead. Bent over like a grub, I hurriedly rolled across the ground.

Slice! Spurt!

A chill ran through me. I felt a sharp blade cut away a handful of my hair.

As the auras flying in from all sides grazed my body, stinging pain flared across my skin.

After coming all this way, I'm rolling around like a lazy donkey?[3251]

Tears blurred my vision. The one small mercy was that the fanatics hadn't expected this either.

[3250] *Inshallah* is an Arabic expression meaning "if God wills."

[3251] *Narye tagon* is an idiom for an undignified evasive roll, likened to a lazy donkey rolling on the ground.

…It’d be weirder if they had.

What kind of lunatic lands in the middle of his enemies and starts vomiting? I fought down the churn in my stomach and swung the thing in my hand.

Thwack!

Flesh and blood flew with a dull impact.

The Prophet’s arm, torn off in the aftermath of the Blink spell, made an excellent club.

“Oh, power attack.”

“You bastard! How dare you profane His sacred flesh—”

“Then let me rephrase. Holy attack.”

Wham! Wham! Wham!

The three nearest fanatics fell like dominoes.

I hurled the ruined arm like an axe, then stamped my foot in the middle of the enemies packed around me.

Thud!

A shock wave rumbled outward. The ground sank for several meters[3252] in every direction, and the fanatics staggered as they lost their footing. Their weapons veered off course with them and swept past my body.

Whoosh! Spurt!

The aura and wind pressure carried by the blades left fine cuts in my skin.

That alone told me how skilled they were.

More than half are B-rank or higher.

And I’d counted hundreds of them. The followers the Doppelganger had raised somewhere in a desolate desert no one could find were a match for the World Hunter Federation’s elite, locked in battle barely a hundred meters[3253] away.

Crazy bastard. No—crazy bastards.

The Doppelganger and its disgusting followers were all shit from the same cesspit.

I swallowed the curses rising in my throat and thrust out both hands.

Fanatics who looked like tanks raised round, enchanted shields across my path. They weren’t enough to stop the ten streaks of Finger Qi I’d fired a step ahead of them.

Fwoosh! Thud-thud-thud!

The wind blew, and ten fanatics fell like reed leaves.

Through the gap that opened for an instant, I caught a glimpse of someone’s back. I’d lost sight of him for a moment.

There you are.

[3252] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

[3253] A hundred meters is about 328 ft.

The glimpse was brief, but I'd seen enough. The bastard was leaving the battlefield.

He was using the countless followers he'd raised as bait, treading across their blood like a carpet as he fled beyond my reach.

Just as he always had. And…

He'll keep doing it.

Too many people had already died.

I still didn't know what plan the bastard had spent more than thirty years building. But I had to bring it down here, today, with my own hands.

If I didn't, my world—and the people in it—would fall apart.

"You won't get past—!"

Crack. Thud-thud!

I broke the neck of the fanatic blocking my way and used his body to shield myself from an arrow flying in from ahead.

Its mana-infused head punched through the corpse, grazed my cheek, then lodged in the eye of another fanatic nearby.

"Gyaaaaaah!"

Blood sprayed as he screamed in pain. Moments later, a cold slicing sound cut the scream short.

Slice.

A red line crossed the fanatic's neck. A heavy voice, announcing his death, rang out.

"Hassan. Brave warrior of God. We shall meet again in the Kingdom of Heaven, far in the future."

Thud.

The screaming stopped. His head fell.

His body crumpled like a scarecrow and never moved again. Only then did faint beads of blood begin to gather on the cut surface of his neck.

This is…

Even after facing countless powerful fighters, I couldn't help being astonished by the skill. I stopped and looked at the speaker, eyes wide.

Among the fanatics surrounding me stood a sturdy old man, tall as an iron tower, looking straight at me.

"This is the first time we've met face to face, Jin Taekyung, king of the wicked heretics."

His turban was wrapped so carefully that not a strand of hair escaped it. His back was straight, his gaze deep and still.

I'd sensed it from the moment I opened my eyes here: the old man was immensely powerful.

Not merely as one of the Awakened known as Hunters in the modern world, but as a martial artist in his own right.

And I knew instinctively that if the Doppelganger was the untouchable symbol the fanatics revered, this old man was their real commander-in-chief and the heart of their fighting force.

"Yahya Muhammad Ahmad Bedouin… Did I get that right? That's one hell of a long name."

As I read aloud the information in the holographic window floating above his head, the old man's eyes widened in surprise.

"How do you know my name?"

"God told me, you crazy old bastard."

"Nonsense. God would never tell such a thing to the king of the wicked heretics."

"You're the one talking nonsense. I'm an atheist, so I'm not a heretic—and I'm definitely not a king."

"Do not deny the existence of the great God with your vile tongue, demon."

"Come on, sir. It's time to take your pills."

Slide. Thump.

His robe slipped from his shoulder and spread over the ground.

Holding a crooked staff in one hand and a scimitar—what Murim would call a curved saber—in the other, the old man stepped forward. The air grew cold, and the ring around me tightened.

Step. Sssssss.

Killing intent from every direction made my whole body prickle.

It wasn't just the old man in front of me. I could see more than thirty men in black, wrapped head to toe in black robes and turbans, scattered among the fanatics.

Those are the real deal.

Every one of them was skilled enough to hold their own anywhere in the world. And unlike Hunters who weren't used to killing other people, they showed no hesitation at all.

Seasoned killers.

Perhaps it wasn't my imagination that I saw the martial artists of Dark Heaven superimposed on them.

They were alike in their blind loyalty and faith in one being, and even more so in their willingness to do any terrible thing for that being.

And…

I've killed countless people like them.

There were too many people in the world who needed killing. That was all.

Deep down, I had a vague sense that an absolute being called God might exist in this world. But I didn't believe in him or pledge my loyalty to him.

In the end, people were the ones who accomplished things through hardship. Like countless others, I'd survived that way.

But if that god was the one who'd slipped a beat-up capsule to someone who'd suddenly lost his job a year ago—to a young man climbing a steep alley, worried about how he'd get through this month… Well, in that case, I might be willing to believe in him a little.

"Then your deaths at my hands will be God's will, too."

I muttered the words and closed my hand around empty air. Where there had been nothing but air and dust, my fingers caught a spear that had been away from my side for a while.

The old man saw something even magic couldn't explain, and a stubborn crease formed between his brows.

"Demon. You truly are a demon."

I wanted to tell the old man in front of me, and the fanatics all around us, that the real demon was running away and leaving them behind. That the monster they called a prophet was racing toward a new catastrophe.

Instead, I stepped forward. The wind burst, space vanished, and I charged.

Whoosh.

A scorching wind swept away the darkness. White Flame's spearhead traced a path no one could block.

Slice—KRRRUNCH!

A thick mist of blood settled over everything.

Chapter 819

Fanatics and Hunters.

The battle between two forces, waged around the canyon, could be summed up in four characters:

Advance and retreat.

The fighting was that fierce, and everyone on both sides had put their lives on the line.

Some fought for a faith they had held all their lives, one they could not even imagine was false. Others fought for convictions just as firm.

And so they fought.

It was a clash of faith and conviction, and at the same time, a holy war.

But amid so much blood and death, whether anyone was religious no longer mattered.

Demons.

They were human beings with the same appearance, but each held a different standard for good and evil. Their eyes met between the blades lunging toward one another, burning with murderous intent.

“Die!”

Clang!

Sword met saber. Blue sparks flew with a sharp screech. Blood spurted amid ragged shouts, impossible to tell who had cried out.

Slice—shaaak!

No scream followed. The fanatic, his throat cut, glared at the Hunter before him with venom in his eyes, then collapsed.

Blue light flashed above the fallen body.

“Watch out!”

Whoosh! Boom!

A warning shout mingled with the roar of impact. A tank stared at the arrowhead protruding halfway through his enormous tower shield, inches from his face, and swallowed.

If he’d raised his shield just a fraction later, he would have died.

But Hunters lived closer to death than anyone. Everyone here had survived countless brushes with it.

The tank grabbed the arrow and snapped it in two, then shouted in a hoarse voice.

“They’re coming! Hold formation!”

Rumble!

Countless flashes rained down. Sharp blades and heavy clubs struck, and even fanatics on the verge of death forced themselves upright and charged.

The impacts hammered the shields so hard that even veteran tanks, hardened by years of combat, thought they might die.

“Arrrgh!”

Grit.

They shouted to wring out the last of their strength and clenched their teeth until they felt ready to break. Their feet slid backward under the pressure, carving deep furrows in the ground.

“Hold the line! If we break, it’s over!”

Even the commanders’ shouts seemed distant.

The enemy had an overwhelming advantage in numbers.

Less than three hours had passed since the battle against the monster army. That fight had drained them in body and mind, and the fanatics were the worst opponents they could have faced now.

Ten thousand of them.

They kept charging even after their chests were cut open or their limbs were severed.

Decades ago, the Doppelganger had raised these fanatics somewhere in this barren desert, hidden from the world, under the name of the Prophet. They were monsters of another kind.

Thrust!

A sword bearing a faint aura pierced a fanatic’s chest and emerged from his back.

It was a grievous wound. Even if he used a potion right away, there was no telling whether he’d live or die. Yet the fanatic whose chest had been pierced bared his blood-soaked teeth and smiled.

“I-Inshallah[3254]…”

“…!”

The madness in that fading voice made the Hunter freeze.

A chill swept over him. By the time he came to his senses, it was too late.

Whoosh!

A sharp whistle cut past his ear. At the same instant, his vision went dark.

Slump. Thud.

“Hans! Hans!”

The Hunter who caught his falling comrade bit his lip.

But the man who had saved his life time and again—and whose life he had saved in turn—did not answer.

[3254] *Inshallah* is Arabic for “if God wills.”

The dagger lodged squarely between Hans's eyes had taken his voice and his life.

Goddammit.

The Hunter laid down the body, his gaze darkening.

The canyon was an ideal battlefield for facing a larger force, but no matter how efficiently they fought, casualties were unavoidable.

Especially against madmen who saw death as martyrdom.

It was just as their ranks were about to crumble before the wave of fanatics charging without regard for their lives—

Fwoosh.

A fierce heat washed over everyone's heads.

Before anyone could look up, fire came pouring down like a meteor shower with a fierce whistle.

Whooooooosh!

Dozens of fireballs appeared above the Hunters and fell toward the battlefield, toward the fanatics who charged without end.

As everyone stared, mouths open, one name flashed through their minds.

Magic Johnson.

The Grand Mage said to have been blessed by mana. The world's greatest War Mage, whose power had been proven during the Great Cataclysm, was finally showing what he could do.

A powerful area spell that could turn the tide of battle.

That's it. With that…

Every Hunter thought the same thing. No—they were certain.

With Jin Taekyung nowhere to be seen, Magic Johnson was their surest bet to lead them to victory.

At least, they were certain until blue waves surged up from parched land that held nothing but sand and stone in every direction.

"Aqua Storm!"

"Aqua Storm!"

"Aqua Storm!"

Fwooooooosh!

Dozens of voices rang as one. Spheres of water piled upon spheres of water and rose into an enormous tidal wave.

And then…

BOOM!

A roar like the sky splitting apart shook the air.

Water and fire. Fire and water.

The opposing forces met and mingled. Then they collided.

With a shockwave that shook everything within a radius of hundreds of meters[3255], they exploded above the heads of the Hunters and fanatics.

Fwoosh! Boom-boom!

“Gyaaaah!”

“M-My God!”

Someone screamed from beyond the steam that swept through the area on the wind.

The thick steam blinded everyone to what had happened. But Magic Johnson, who had cast the spell, knew better than anyone.

His magic had been canceled out.

Blocked. Almost completely.

Only almost because part of his Fire Storm had engulfed some fanatics. Even so, he could tell the damage was far less than he had expected.

They were ready for it.

Magic Johnson had seen them clearly: thirty mages emerging under heavy guard.

Their turbans were pulled low. Every last one was A-rank and, like him, a War Mage specialized in combat.

The Doppelganger…

Magic Johnson swallowed a groan.

He didn’t need to wonder who had built the force before him.

The Great Cataclysm had been a time of immense chaos. Thirty years was long enough for nature itself to change, and the desert must have been the perfect place to hide something.

How the Doppelganger had gathered and trained them was not what Magic Johnson wanted to know.

His question went to the beginning and end of it all.

What do you want badly enough to have prepared all this?

But his question reached no one. Even if the Doppelganger had known what he was thinking, it would not have answered.

No—it would not even have had time.

At that very moment, the Doppelganger was leaving the battlefield with a small escort.

I have to chase it. I can’t let it get away.

But despite his determination, Magic Johnson couldn’t move easily.

Unlike monsters, the fanatics were thoroughly trained. They knew what mattered most in this battle.

[3255] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

They had more than ten times the Hunters' numbers and used them to attack in rotating waves.

And…

"Stop them! Those two must not get through!"

"Open fire!"

Magic Johnson and the Skeleton King.

The fanatics concentrated their attacks on the two strongest members of the Hunters' force—the two who could also be called its commanders.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Boom-boom!

Arrows and magic rained down. Even a Grand Mage like Magic Johnson could not afford to ignore the attacks coming without pause from every direction.

He had already spent a great deal of his stamina and mana. The fanatics, by contrast, kept drawing on their strength as they cried out for a holy war.

The Skeleton King was in much the same position.

Slice. Slice. Slice!

His Bone Sword swept in smooth arcs.

But before the bodies crumpling in sprays of blood could hit the ground, dazzling flashes cut through them and shot toward him.

"This is insane…!"

The Skeleton King was aghast. Since coming into this world, he had never encountered people this crazy.

Much less ten thousand of them.

They're insane. Completely insane.

He wielded the power of death, yet the endless wave of fanatics was nearly enough to overwhelm even him.

Every human feared death. Even he, an Undead Monster, feared Erasure. That fear seemed as inevitable as being born.

So why weren't these humans afraid to die?

No—what had made them this way?

They're the real monsters…

Thrust-thrust-thrust!

Swallowing a groan, he swung his Bone Sword and cut through a human body.

When he took one down, three more came. When he took down three, ten came. And when he felled those, fanatics rushed in from every direction, swinging their weapons.

"Die, demon!"

Crunch!

A blade cut through him with a chilling sound. Naturally, he felt no pain.

The Skeleton King sighed at the sword piercing his chest.

“Who are you calling a demon?”

Whoosh—thrust!

He turned his wrist. A bone shard shot out and pierced his attacker’s throat.

With a gurgling sound, the fanatic fell. The Skeleton King kicked him hard, clearing some space. At that moment—

Whoom.

A dark shape came flying toward him with a heavy whistle. He caught it in a hurry.

It coughed up blood. A human, still alive.

And one he knew.

Goddammit. This guy…

There was no mistaking him, even covered head to toe in blood.

The Skeleton King raised an Undead Monster with what little magical power he had left, then tapped the man’s cheek.

“Hey. Human with a fine-looking build. Can you hear me?”

Cough. Choi Minwoo spat up blood again, then answered in a voice on the verge of fading.

“Yes. Very clearly.”

“Good. We’re short on time, so listen carefully. You’re not going to die, so don’t worry. And even if you do, I’ll bring you back as an undead, so don’t—dammit. He passed out.”

The Skeleton King clicked his tongue and stood. Then he added, almost as an afterthought, “Still, he held out remarkably well, all things considered. Don’t you think?”

Whoooosh! Slice!

An aura swept past the Skeleton King’s head in place of an answer.

He watched blond hair flutter through the air, muttered a string of curses, then faced forward. Through the thick steam, he saw a man.

“Not at all. That bastard is trash.”

His hair was disheveled, and a wound crossed his cheek.

The Skeleton King gave a quiet laugh at the fury in the man’s eyes.

“No matter how I look at it, he fought well. When he wakes up, I’ll have to praise him myself.”

“Shut your filthy mouth, cursed demon.”

“When you die, you’ll find out which of us was the demon.”

The Skeleton King pulled the hilt of the sword from Choi Minwoo’s hand. Sacred light spread along the blade of the [Hero’s Sword].

“Get in here, quick. Before someone scarier than me shows up.”

Chapter 820

Everything alive is born into a struggle.

Humans, monsters, animals in the wild or behind fences, even green plants—all of them.

Even when survival itself wasn't the reason to struggle, you had to fight and take what you wanted.

And under this absolute law, I was no exception.

Crunch!

Minimum force. Minimum speed.

That was enough. I twisted aside, leaving behind a fanatic who collapsed with his brains spilling out.

Whoosh!

The air split. A flash dropped from empty space and skimmed past me by half a handspan.[3256]

Between the pitch-black robe and turban that covered him completely, I saw his eyes widen. The White Flame's spearhead was reflected in them.

Thump. Splurt!

His head flew up. More enemies and their auras surged through the spraying blood.

As blades came at me from every direction, I tightened my grip on the blood-slick spear shaft.

Hoo.

I breathed out. The world slowed. My muscles loosened, and the flames coiling around my spearhead flickered.

Like a tail fluttering in the wind.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Flames surged. The enemies' auras flashing from every direction drove away the darkness racing toward the dim dawn.

I turned, my whole body moving in one smooth motion.

Shiiiiing!

Blue-white flames swept across the space between us. They were faster than any aura bearing down on me, their edge too sharp for anyone to stop.

Slice.

With a clean, cold sound, a sword tilted in its wielder's hand.

[3256] A *ppyeom*, or handspan, is the distance from an outstretched thumb to little finger. It varies by person; half a handspan is roughly 10 cm (4 in).

No—faint lines had already appeared across the bodies of dozens of fanatics, frozen in place.

“Ghk. Ghrk…”

Trembling pupils. A fading voice.

But no words or actions could stop death from bearing down without mercy.

Fwooooooosh!

Flames raced along the faint lines, devouring their lives.

Thick sprays of blood mist blanketed the steam hanging low over the battlefield.

Thud-thud-thud!

Blood rained down on my head.

At the same time, flesh, bones, and organs—torn apart by a single horizontal strike—tumbled across the ground. Hundreds of fanatics had already fallen the same way.

“De…mon…”

Someone’s voice reached my ears. Of course, it belonged to one of the fanatics, someone whose face and name I didn’t know—and an enemy I had to kill.

Pfft!

I thrust out a hand without looking. Finger Qi shot from it, and a familiar bell rang.

Ding.

Another notification of death.

The fanatics surrounding me stopped moving.

Most of them probably couldn’t understand even a quarter of what they’d just seen.

How their comrades had died. Why they couldn’t wound me, even with so many fighters.

They would die with those questions unanswered.

All except one.

Whoom. Boom!

My spearhead struck the crescent curve of a saber.

The impact made my ears ring. I’d blocked the attack before I heard it coming. Now I stared past the white scimitar’s blade at the old man holding it.

“You lousy old bastard. Finally crawled out, did you?”

“I was waiting for my prey to tire.”

The old man with the long name, Yahya Muhammad Ahmad Bedouin, twisted his scimitar as he answered.

Ka-ga-gak!

Auras of different colors collided, sparking like lightning. A small explosion waited at their tips.

Boom!

The impact roared like cannon fire and traveled down my spear.

Its force drove me backward. The old man hadn't moved an inch, and the sight made me realize something.

"Don't tell me…"

"You've finally understood, King of the heathens."

A smile formed on his wrinkled lips.

Two entirely different energies, neither of which he'd revealed until now, coexisted along the scimitar's blade pointed at me.

Mana. And magical power.

As those two words crossed my mind, the old man continued.

"I, Yahya Muhammad Ahmad Bedouin, am a warrior chosen by God."

"Huh."

A hollow laugh escaped me.

The Doppelganger hadn't raised only Michael Silbert. It had chosen its most loyal, most insane fanatic and taught him to wield magical power.

If more fanatics had been capable of accepting those two opposing energies, the Doppelganger would've churned out half-human, half-demon monsters like they were coming off an assembly line.

"I knew you were out of your mind from the start…but you're no ordinary crazy old bastard."

"If that is what you wish to believe, then believe it."

The old man shook his head and looked at me with gray eyes.

"You know nothing. Dozens, hundreds died trying to be chosen by God. But I alone survived."

"So being 'chosen by God' just means mixing a human and a monster half and half? Does that make a half-and-half order of black-bean noodles and spicy seafood noodles a warrior of God too?"

"The great Prophet said that monsters, too, are God's creations—calamities sent to punish the fallen humans of this world."

"Bullshit. Anyone listening would think you lived in some other world, not this one. By your logic, you're one of those fallen humans too, you crazy old bastard."

"Though fallen, I was given a chance at salvation. I inherited two powers that can never coexist. That is who I am: a warrior and a punisher chosen by God."

The madness in his faith came through with every word.

But a madman doesn't know he's talking crazy.

Even if the Doppelganger gathered every fanatic in one place and made a public apology to the entire nation, they wouldn't believe it.

Their faith was their whole life, their reason for living. It was even bound up with what they believed awaited them after death.

In the end, there was only one thing I could say to fanatics like them.

"You fucking lunatics. Talking to you is a waste of time."

"Remember one thing."

Step.

The old man came toward me. The fanatics who had faltered found their fighting spirit again.

"Your steps will never reach the Prophet."

"Fuck off."

Whoosh.

I shot forward like the wind as I answered.

Our brief exchange had given my body time to recover from the strain of battle. It had also given me time to assess the situation.

It's even. Fierce, but we're holding our own.

The Hunters' shouts, which had been distant, were drawing closer.

But to overcome odds of more than ten to one and win, we had to cut off the head.

It was the best thing I could do before chasing the Doppelganger, which was still fleeing.

Thwack! Crunch!

My spear drove through three fanatics and came free.

Without hesitation, the old man threw his subordinates in as bait and swung his scimitar at my neck.

Whoosh! Slice!

I bent at the waist. The slash missed me and cut apart the fanatics charging from behind.

The old man sprang back, ready for my counterattack, and shouted in a cold voice.

"That demon means to harm the great Prophet! Give your lives to stop him!"

Damn old bastard.

He might've been the most fanatical of the fanatics, but the experience he'd gained over the years was no joke.

He knew exactly what his job was, and he kept his head even in the heat of battle.

If this drags on any longer…I'll really lose him for good.

As I cut down the fanatics rushing in from every direction like moths to a flame, I thought. No—I calculated.

How much strength I could muster right now.

How to end this fight as quickly as possible.

And how much I'd have left when I could finally chase the Doppelganger again.

Then, amid the unending blood and screams, I realized I'd been thinking about something stupid.

Fuck. When did I start calculating every little thing?

When had it started? Every moment had become a struggle.

Each time, I'd had to forget the past and put the future out of my mind.

That was how you survived. Only by betting everything on the present could you think about the past and move toward the future.

Slice!

Hot pain ran down my back. My exhausted body felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton. Weapons came at me like gears turning together, large and small, opening wounds all over me.

But because of that, my hesitant body and mind woke up completely.

Grit.

I clenched my teeth against the pain and hurled the spear I held in a reverse grip at the fanatics charging straight at me.

The space was too tight for a proper throw, but one step was all I needed.

Cr-r-runch!

Flesh and blood were crushed. They screamed with pain enough to make them forget their faith.

The old man's command rang out through their cries.

"Now!"

Now? Now what?

Oh. My weapon?

"So what?"

I spat out the blood running between my lips and reached out. The Flame Divine Palm I'd held back for the sake of an efficient fight erupted.

The fanatics packed around me went down in flames.

At the sight of their comrades writhing in agony, the others faltered.

One more.

Fwoosh—BOOM!

Blue-white flames lit the darkness. They burned flesh and turned the blood and bones within it to ash.

"Aaaaaagh!"

"Hng…!"

That was when it happened.

One fanatic, who had unconsciously stepped backward before that cruel, dazzling sight of a mass execution by fire, suddenly had his head fly into the air.

Slice!

The sound of the cut came a moment later. The old man, who had slipped out of my sight, gave a cold command.

“Fire.”

Whoooooosh!

Dozens of arrows whistled through the air, one after another.

By the time I spotted the archers and their dark bows through the thinning ranks of fanatics, it was too late.

Thud-thud-thud!

“Guh!”

“Ghk.”

The arrows rained down without regard for friend or foe.

The fanatics hesitating around me fell like straw. Mana-laden arrows pierced their bodies and kept coming toward me.

Whoosh.

The whistle of their flight seemed to stretch on and on.

Dark arrowheads wrapped in blood and mana.

As the world slowed, one thought came to me with absolute certainty.

I can’t dodge this.

Of course, I could knock aside half of them. Of the rest, I could somehow twist my body to evade half.

But the Fire Dragon Armor hadn’t finished repairing itself. I would still have to take some damage.

But why?

A strange feeling came over me.

My instincts seemed to reject the judgment my mind had made.

A strange sense of déjà vu ran through me, as though every part of me were taking another step into an unknown realm.

I can do this.

A strange certainty, like a conviction, took over my body and mind. An inexplicable tickling sensation began around the center of my chest and spread through my entire body.

Right now.

I reached out as if in a trance, toward the dozens of arrows almost at my face.

No—not just the arrows. Everything around them.

Shhhhaaa.

Time began to move again, but no one spoke.

I stared silently at the arrows stopped in midair, then snapped my fingers.

Swish.

The arrows pointed toward the enemy. And once again, the power of my newly advanced Middle Dantian pressed down on the space around us.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

As the clear chimes pierced my ears, I smiled at the old man, frozen like a statue.

“Whoa. It worked?”

“T-This is—!”

“Refund, you fucking bastard.”

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

The arrows’ powerful whistle swallowed the words he was about to say.

Chapter 821

The moment dozens of arrows stopped in midair, the old man doubted his own eyes.

Magic?

No. That couldn't be.

Mages and warriors shared the same root—mana—but their trunks and branches grew in entirely different directions.

That was why a Spellblade was considered as impossible as the coexistence of mana and magical power. Perhaps even more so.

But if it isn't magic, how…?

The old man had long since reached the realm of the superhuman.

In his youth, he had ranged across battlefields amid the turbulent politics of the Middle East, protecting his tribe. Then, as the Great Cataclysm began in his middle age, he awakened to a power he had never known existed.

Even without accepting magical power, he would have been strong enough to stand shoulder to shoulder with the heroes of the Great Cataclysm.

That made what he was seeing all the harder to believe.

There was a clear, undeniable limit to what a warrior like him could move using mana.

And those are arrows. Dozens of them, fired from close range.

The unit waiting in the rear was made up of elite troops he had personally trained—swords and shields he had saved for the most crucial moment.

Yet the arrows those very troops had loosed had been stopped.

No—they were under control.

Dozens of arrows, shot with tremendous force and filled with mana, controlled by a single gesture.

Whoooosh.

The air stopped. The wind, thick with the stench of blood, vanished.

In that space where everything else seemed to have disappeared like a desert mirage, the wave of steel pouring toward one man turned.

Swish.

Dozens of arrowheads glinted in the darkness, their mana still intact. They pointed toward the men who had shot them. And…

"Wow. It actually worked."

They were ready to obey the will of their new master.

Jin Taekyung.

The old man stared at the young man smiling beneath a coating of blood and clenched his teeth without meaning to.

A groan slipped through his bloodless lips.

“Th-This is…!”

What is this? What have you done?

He wanted to ask, but the young man did not wait for an old fool blinded by false faith to find his words.

“Refund, you fucking bastard.”

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

A fierce whistle of air shattered the silence. Hundreds of fanatics surrounding them watched the unbelievable sight with vacant eyes.

As if an invisible giant had drawn a bowstring, dozens of steel arrows came raining down, faster and harder than before.

All aimed at one man.

The old commander-in-chief who led the fanatics.

“Block—!”

Boom!

The unfinished shout vanished beneath a small explosion.

A sword swung to knock the arrows aside flew into the air, along with its wielder’s arm.

“Gaaah!”

The scream came a moment later. Then dozens of streaks of light swept in, cutting through and smashing everything in their path.

Grit.

The metallic taste of blood filled the old man’s mouth.

He had bitten his lip hard enough to draw blood without noticing. He brought down his scimitar, unleashing a murky force of mingled magical power and mana.

Whoooooom!

The immense wind pressure rushing off the blade pushed back the arrows flying in from the front.

Jin Taekyung had been surrounded, forced to face arrows coming from every direction. The old man, by contrast, had fanatics around him willing to die to stop the arrows.

Perhaps that was why he stepped forward at once, turning to the offensive. Why he trusted the dozens of followers surrounding him like shields.

The next moment, that trust vanished.

Whish.

At the faint whistle of air, the old man’s eyes widened.

Arrows were flying toward him, weaving around the fanatics as though they were alive.

This is impossible…!

A cry like a scream rose to his tongue, then disappeared. No—he wasn't even given time to let it out.

He sucked in a breath and swung his scimitar. As streaks of light filled the air around him, he knew.

Damn it.

Unlike Jin Taekyung, he could not escape this attack.

Crack!

Arrows caught in the scimitar's path bent and broke.

But even the old man, who had reached the superhuman realm, could not deflect or dodge them all.

Thud-thud-thud!

"Guh!"

Blood spilled through his clenched teeth. His vision blurred, and pain struck all through his body.

Ribs. Legs. Chest. Back.

He felt arrowheads pierce armor and flesh and shatter bone. The heat they carried seeped deep into his organs.

"Cough."

His once-sturdy legs trembled. As the old man staggered, more than ten arrows buried deep in his body, the fanatics supporting him shouted like they were screaming in despair.

"No!"

"Amir! Amir! Please, stay with us!"

"What are you waiting for? Get him somewhere safe!"

The fanatics, finally grasping what had happened, were more shaken than ever.

If the Doppelganger, calling itself the Prophet, was their spiritual pillar, the old man was the warrior chief favored by God—the general who led them.

A voice pierced their ears like a spike.

"Who said you could?"

"…!"

"…!"

The shock hit like a bucket of cold water.

Heavy footsteps advanced.

"I asked you. Who said you could move?"

The voice was low. The face above it was worn with fatigue.

But the fanatics stepping backward without realizing it saw none of that. In their wide eyes, there was only one thing:

The flames flickering in his gaze.

“Did all you bastards eat a load of dates together? Not one of you can answer me.”

His blood-crusted lips twitched. Jin Taekyung smiled and reached out, and an immense, invisible force pressed down on the space around them.

No—it ruled it.

Hssssss.

The air stopped. The wind scattered.

Jin Taekyung felt an intangible force welling up from his chest, from his Middle Dantian.

Everything within a radius of dozens of meters[3257] already belonged to him. The hundreds of fanatics staring at him in shock were invaders. Demons defiling not just this land, but the entire world.

No. To you, I’m the demon.

Jin Taekyung looked down at the frozen fanatics with disgust.

He did not want to kill them. He only wanted peace.

He was no Killing Ghost, forever thirsting for blood. Whenever another Hunter who had united with the others under one banner for the sake of the world fell, he felt pain and sorrow.

But…

In the end, this too was a struggle for each side’s purpose.

To gain peace, they had to wage war. And in that war, rivers of blood and death would flow.

There was no other choice.

“It’s too late to turn back now. For me and for you.”

As Jin Taekyung’s quiet voice rang out—

Roooooom.

The still air and wind stirred again.

At that same moment, the old man got back to his feet. Magical power had given him a recovery beyond anything human, but waiting for him was a mass of steel filling the air.

“This is…”

He could not finish. No one could have.

All they could do was stare.

Spears. Sabers. Swords. Axes. Countless arrows and fragments of broken blades.

[3257] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–295 ft.

The wave of steel had left its dead former owners behind and taken a new master. It surged through the air, cold edges glinting as each weapon turned toward its target.

At the center of it all stood Jin Taekyung.

“Any last words?”

The old man sighed at the impossible sight. A murky force, neither monster nor human, overflowed from the scimitar in his hand.

“Inshallah.”

May it be God’s will.

With that prayer ringing in his heart, the old man stepped forward alone.

He left behind his followers, paralyzed with fear and waiting for death. He went forward with the duty and pride of a warrior chosen by God.

And yet, why?

Is this—is this really what God wanted?

For the first time, the old man who had believed in God and the Prophet more than anyone felt doubt.

But even now, as he charged like a streak of light and watched the rain of steel pour from the sky, brimming with lava-hot mana, he couldn’t find an answer.

Answer me. Is this truly the promised land you spoke of?

But the old man’s god did not answer.

It never had, from the distant past until now. And it seemed it never would.

Only a faint voice reached his ears. He could not tell whether it belonged to a god or a demon.

“Die, old man.”

Fwoooosh!

A gale swept through. A wave of steel, falling in place of damp rain, swallowed him.

As his body and power—part monster, part human—were smashed to pieces, the old man heard a terrible scream echoing faintly.

“Gaaah!”

His vision darkened. His consciousness scattered. The warriors of God met their brutal end.

Ah.

At last, he knew the answer to his question.

This was not the promised land. It was the land of death.

Thud.

His lifeless body crumpled to the ground.

Though he had found the answer in his final moment, the old man’s face was twisted with anger and disbelief.

It happened in an instant.

Weapons swinging at one another stopped in midair. Shouts forced from hoarse throats cut off.

Every head turned in the same direction.

Fwaaaash!

It was a roar and a scream at once.

A scream of steel raining through the air. And a scream of terror from people who sensed their own deaths.

Kwaaaang!

Dust billowed upward. Through sand surging like a whirlwind, streams of blood spurted like fountains.

Splash—splat!

Dozens of meters[3258] away, fanatics stared blankly at the sight and blinked.

Blood rained onto their heads and ran down in sticky streams, along with something hard and something soft.

It did not take long to realize what had fallen on them: human bone and flesh.

“Ah… ah…”

Their hands and feet trembled. The clatter of teeth spread among the fanatics like an epidemic.

They all knew that carefully chosen elite troops had been waiting in the far rear with the commander-in-chief, ready to join the fight.

Now that was a fact of the past.

Annihilation.

Everyone on the battlefield understood instinctively.

No one could survive the storm of steel raging there.

No—there was one person who could.

Jin Taekyung.

As the name surfaced in every mind—

Kwaaaaa.

The whirlwind slowly settled. Within it, someone’s silhouette wavered like heat haze.

[3258] Dozens of meters is roughly 20–90 m, or about 66–295 ft.

Chapter 822

In the wake of the Great Cataclysm, the boundary between what humanity considered common sense and nonsense crumbled like a sandcastle.

Awakened people, monsters, magic, Gates.

Things that had existed only in novels and movies became reality.

Calamity became a neighbor, and the word *death* came cheap.

But humans are adaptable creatures.

They quickly accepted the unbelievable reality before them and made the impossible their new normal.

They thought nothing like it would ever happen again in human history.

No—they hoped it wouldn't. Please.

But at this very moment, in an unnamed canyon in the Rub' al Khali Desert, those who had been piling up blood and bodies without end had no choice but to admit it.

The common sense they had accepted had crumbled once more.

Roooooar.

The rain of steel lashing through the darkness stopped. The whirlwind that had seemed ready to swallow the entire desert slowly died away.

Amid the silence and shock that gripped them all, thousands of eyes settled on the figure who had emerged.

"Oh my God."

"What the hell did I just see?"

The Hunters stared in awe and elation.

"He's a demon. He has to be."

"Inshallah.[3259] God…"

The fanatics trembled with fear and hatred.

And among all the people gathered there, the one being who wasn't human spat out the one word they had all wanted to say.

"Monster."

The Skeleton King's mouth curled as he looked at the man before him.

"I told you, didn't I? Let's finish this before someone scarier than me shows up."

"…!"

The man's eyes widened. His hair was disheveled, and wounds large and small covered his body.

He had already been struggling against the Skeleton King, but now his injuries were the last thing on his mind.

[3259] *Inshallah* is an Arabic expression meaning "if God wills."

“How… How can anyone do that?”

The man muttered in a dazed voice.

His bulging eyes stared past the whirlwind, at the blood and corpses it had left behind.

A thousand.

There had been a thousand warriors waiting in the rear.

The finest of the elite, held in reserve for the final blow. And with them, Amir—their greatest warrior and commander.

No. He *had* been with them.

Until that enormous whirlwind of steel swept them away.

They’re all dead? Killed by one man?

It was impossible to believe. Impossible to understand.

The man’s hand trembled around his sword hilt. A groan escaped through his clenched teeth.

“Th-That’s impossi—”

“Possible.”

His wavering voice cut off.

The Skeleton King had severed his words like a guillotine blade. He went on evenly.

“Jin Taekyung can do it.”

“Shut your mouth!”

The man’s furious roar split the desert. He glared at the Skeleton King, his eyes blazing.

Shhhhh.

Immense killing intent and aura rose from him, swallowing the space around him.

An ordinary Hunter would have struggled even to breathe beneath that pressure. The Skeleton King didn’t so much as blink.

To the undead, killing intent was more familiar than anything else.

Simply by existing, he was already in contact with death.

The man’s aura was no different.

Half as strong as that guy, if I’m generous.

Thinking of *that guy*, shimmering in the distance like a mirage, the Skeleton King let out a quiet snort.

The world called beings like him monsters. But the real monster was someone else.

“Why did you have to do something like this? If you’d stayed quietly tucked away in some corner of the desert, you wouldn’t have made that guy angry.”

"…God, God chose us. The great God Himself sent the Prophet to lead His warriors to the promised land!"

"The promised land?"

The Skeleton King glanced around as he echoed the words.

Corpses lay in every direction.

Blood flowed like a river, rising to their ankles. Limbs and chunks of flesh—no one knew whose—bloomed across the desert like flowers.

"Surely this isn't the promised land you've been blathering on about."

"…!"

"Unless you promised God you'd all die here together. In that case, I'll give you that one."

The man's eyes wavered. So did those of every fanatic around him.

The Skeleton King's voice, infused with magical power, carried far enough to reach Hunter and fanatic alike.

Each word poured cold water on the flames of fanaticism that had seemed as though they would burn forever. And each word made the Hunters take up their weapons again.

"There was a human. No, there were humans. Frail creatures compared to me, born with death as their fate."

The Skeleton King remembered.

Countless faces he had encountered since coming into the world flashed before his eyes.

"They fought countless battles and kept dying. But they didn't fight only for the god they believed in."

They had families and friends. People they loved. Values worth protecting.

"I couldn't understand those stupid humans. I couldn't even accept that there were different kinds of death."

But not anymore.

The Skeleton King had watched humans more closely than any other monster had.

He had stood beside them.

And at last, he understood.

The countless deaths he had witnessed could not all be called simply deaths.

"They were sacrifices."

Some people killed for money and power. They abandoned their parents and children, betrayed their lovers and friends.

But there were others who burned like torches and died away like wildfires.

People who went forward prepared to die.

People who stood their ground and fought for others, for a better world, even in the face of death.

The world called them heroes.

It called their deaths sacrifices.

“But what should I call you? What should I call your deaths?”

“…!”

“If you have a mouth, then answer me. You foolish people who brought calamity upon the world after being deceived by an illusion.”

Kiiiiing.

The man swallowed a breath as the fading golden crown above the Skeleton King’s brow began to shine.

His wandering gaze passed over the countless faces surrounding him.

Hatred and contempt.

Resentment and confusion.

And not just from the Hunters.

Even the fanatics under his command were wavering.

Some of them looked at him with eyes clouded by resentment and confusion, then turned away. The sight struck the man as though something solid inside him had suddenly collapsed.

“I, I… I…”

He wanted to speak.

He wanted to shout at the people wavering before him.

Tell them not to be taken in by a demon’s silver tongue.

Tell them not to dare question the great God and His Prophet.

But his tongue wouldn’t move. The hand gripping his sword seemed to be losing its strength.

In his mind, gone blank, the demon’s words from a moment ago repeated without end.

> *But what should I call you? What should I call your deaths?*

The man clenched his teeth without realizing it. Pain shot through a broken molar, but even that felt distant, like a dream.

The corpses of his followers filling every direction.

So did the sticky pool of blood at his feet.

Is this really…

Was this the promised land, meant to be green and beautiful?

Was it the heaven Almighty God and His Prophet had prepared for His people?

The question he had barely managed to keep from speaking echoed through his mind.

And through his dreamlike haze, a dazzling shaft of light brightened the darkness.

Whoooooom.

Golden radiance rose along the many-colored blade.

The light felt so warm. So sacred.

The man even forgot that the Skeleton King was holding the sword.

Looking at the demon who stood before him with the Hero's Sword in hand, shining with a brilliance reserved for the chosen, he found himself asking:

"Are you… really a demon?"

It was at that very moment.

Step.

In a world where everything had stopped, a single person's footfall rang out.

At the same time, a calm voice reached the man's ears.

"You see what you want to believe. Just like you called a monster the Prophet and worshiped it."

The wind held its breath.

Everyone turned in the same direction.

And at the end of all those gazes stood Jin Taekyung.

"Hamid Shah Masoud."

The man stared blankly at Jin Taekyung.

Apart from Amir, no one knew that name. There was no way the man before him could know it.

"How could you know?"

"If I said God told me, would you believe me?"

"…!"

"You're an easy bunch to read. You saw what you wanted to believe, and believed what you wanted to see. All the while telling yourselves this was God's will."

Splash.

He strode forward.

Blood splashed in every direction from a pool with pieces of flesh floating in it. The young man, already drenched in blood, paid it no mind.

"Tens of thousands are dead because of idiots like you. No—hundreds of thousands."

Cities had burned. A massive tidal wave had swept through a harbor.

Countless people had died in sudden disasters. Happy families had vanished, and children who lost their parents had been sent to orphanages.

And none of it had been a natural disaster.

People had caused it.

“There is no God. And even if there is, He wouldn’t be an idiot who watches over trash like you.”

Jin Taekyung spat out each word as he looked across the countless fanatics.

Some staggered in shock. Others wept, belatedly realizing what they had done.

But if a few short words could have changed their hearts, those disasters would never have happened.

“How dare you, you wicked heretic!”

“God is great!”

Papapat!

At those sharp cries, figures rushed him from all sides like streaks of light.

A cold smile touched Jin Taekyung’s lips as he met their hate-filled gazes.

“Yeah. That’s more like it.”

At that moment—

Shwoosh!

Silver flashes shot up from every direction, splitting the wind.

They tore through space, piercing and slicing the blades and bodies hurtling toward him.

Whoooosh! Slice!

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Only then did the survivors understand.

What the earlier whirlwind had been.

And how those caught within its reach had died.

Krrrunch!

An eerie noise filled the space for more than ten meters[3260] around him.

Blood poured down like rain. Arrows and daggers shot through the air, then flew back the way they had come, taking their owners’ lives.

“Guh…!”

They were lucky if they managed a dying gasp.

Of the hundred or so fanatics who had charged at once, half were torn to pieces beyond recognition.

Thud, thud, thud.

Flesh, blood, and bone fragments filled the empty spaces where screams had been.

Hamid Shah Masoud could only stare, eyes wide, as his sword hilt slipped from his hand.

Clang.

No one spoke.

Not the Hunters. Not the fanatics.

[3260] Ten meters is about 33 ft.

Not the Skeleton King, the Hero’s Sword hanging at his side, or Magic Johnson, standing upright in midair.

At this moment, only one person could speak.

He alone could pass judgment or grant forgiveness.

So Hamid Shah Masoud pleaded for mercy in a trembling voice. To survive, he had no choice but to beg for his one and only life.

He let go of his sword and fell to his knees.

He threw his faith, shattered beyond recognition, into the trash.

“P-Please spare me.”

A desperate plea.

Jin Taekyung looked down at him without a flicker in his eyes. Then he reached out.

A searing heat gathered at the tips of his bloodstained fingers.

Thwip. Thud.

A single blast of hot wind.

That was all. The man fell quietly and never got up again.

At last.

Jin Taekyung let out the breath he had been holding and lifted his head.

Clang. Thud-thud.

Countless still-sharp weapons fell, and knees sank into the blood-soaked sand.

Victory had come in the dim light of dawn. The battle was over.

But Jin Taekyung was looking west, where darkness still held.

Chapter 823

Clang. Clatter.

Countless weapons fell onto the blood-soaked ground. Thousands of fanatics sank to their knees like a wave.

The faint light of dawn from the east shone on the scene.

On the battlefield where victory had finally come.

And on the young man who had brought about that unbelievable victory.

Jin Taekyung.

The defeated did not dare raise their heads before him. The victors gazed at their young Alliance Leader with wonder in their eyes.

They had been outnumbered more than ten to one, facing fanatics who charged without fear of death.

The Hunters had been afraid.

Afraid they would never see their families again. Afraid that if they fell in this nameless canyon, an even greater calamity would swallow those who remained.

But their brief fear had been rendered meaningless. Jin Taekyung had ended this massive battle in an instant.

He had been overwhelming—and, in a way, divine.

Everyone who survived knew it.

Jin Taekyung hadn't just cut through the enemy's flesh and bone. He had broken the fanatics' spirits and made them lay down their weapons of their own accord.

Like a scene from a myth.

If miracles exist… this must be what one looks like.

Magic Johnson suddenly felt something stir in his chest. The Grand Mage's gaze, fixed on Jin Taekyung, trembled like ripples on a pond.

He reminds me of him. Astonishingly so.

Old memories rose like heat haze before his eyes.

Memories from more than thirty years ago. Yet every moment he had spent with *him* remained vivid.

The miracle Magic Johnson had witnessed with his own eyes—that great achievement—would be remembered as long as humanity endured.

And so would the young hero standing alone at the center of the now-quiet battlefield.

But Magic Johnson knew something else.

To gain anything in this world—even a miracle—one had to pay its price.

Equivalent exchange is the one unchanging law.

His gaze on Jin Taekyung deepened. Then dazzling light streamed from the tip of the staff he slowly raised.

Fwoooosh.

A flash heralding the end of the fierce battle drove back the darkness and lit the dawn.

The Hunters touched by its gentle warmth finally grasped what had seemed impossible to believe.

They had won.

Today, they had written a new line in history.

Clang-clang-clang!

Blades smeared with blood and flesh thrust toward the sky.

“Waaaaaaah!”

A tremendous roar shook the canyon.

It was joy at victory, mourning for fallen comrades, and reverence offered wholly to one man.

But most of them neither knew nor saw it.

The young hero’s eyes twitched as he stood amid the cheers pouring in from every direction. His fingers had turned white, gripping with all their strength the spear shaft that kept slipping from his hand.

…Fuck.

Jin Taekyung swallowed the curse and forced down the hot surge rising from deep in his chest.

His vision kept blurring. In his ringing ears, the Hunters’ cheers and the System notifications crowded together in a jumble.

> **System** - You have defeated Lv. 140 Hamid Shah Masoud! - You have gained a substantial amount of EXP and Fame! - Level Up! - All status ailments have been removed as a Level Up effect! - Some wounds have been healed as a Level Up effect! - Special debuff Broken Body rejects the healing effect! - Status ailment Mental Strength Depleted rejects the healing effect! - Middle Dantian has reached its limit! Rest as soon as possible to recover your mental strength!

Jin Taekyung’s condition was exactly as the System had described.

His physical wounds and fatigue had recovered, but his Middle Dantian was beyond the System’s power to heal. The catastrophic force he had unleashed earlier could never have come cheaply.

Throb.

He had already wrung himself out to his limit—and beyond it. Even standing was a struggle.

Pain around his heart and mental exhaustion gnawed at him without pause, whispering:

The battle is over.

Your part is done. Rest now.

"Yeah. I've done enough."

The hollow words fell from his lips.

Through his blurred vision, Jin Taekyung looked at the cheering Hunters.

He recognized faces from the battles they had fought together. There were gaps here and there, but he could tell that not many Hunters had died in this one.

If he hadn't pushed his Middle Dantian beyond its limits, more than half the Hunters who had survived would probably be lying across the battlefield by now, growing cold.

That was no exaggeration.

He had brought a grueling battle to a swift victory and stopped more blood from being spilled.

He had brought a battle that would go down in history to an end, all on his own.

But…

It's not over yet.

Jin Taekyung tightened his grip on the spear shaft. He forced his eyes open against their growing weight and looked west, where desert and wilderness stretched into the distance.

There's still something I have to do.

The light had not gone out of his eyes as he stared at the endless horizon.

His gaze was already following someone who had vanished from sight.

The Doppelganger.

Even now, as dawn arrived, the western land where the Doppelganger had disappeared remained shrouded in darkness.

As though its shadow had fallen over it. As though it foretold the great war to come.

I have to go.

The thought was more than resolve. It was almost a duty.

He had to keep moving. He couldn't stop here.

He had to pursue the Doppelganger far to the west and stop the calamity that would strike before long.

Step.

He moved forward as if entranced.

But his mental strength was spent. His body would no longer obey.

He staggered.

Walk forward.

His legs failed to receive that simple command in time and gave way. A wrenching pain gripped his chest, hampering body and mind alike.

Damn it.

He'd hit a wall on his second step.

As his vision slowly tilted, Jin Taekyung stifled a hollow laugh. Then, just as everything seemed to go dark—

Slide. Tap.

His forehead, pitching forward, touched something solid.

A hand reached out from behind and hauled his collapsing body upright. Two voices broke through the ringing in his ears.

"You did good, Jin."

"Pull yourself together, human."

Jin Taekyung blinked.

Now he knew whose hand was holding him up, and what the solid wall in front of him was.

Magic Johnson. And the Skeleton King.

They had come.

A human and a monster. No—his friends had come.

To help him.

Crack.

Through the distant pain, his blurred vision cleared again. Jin Taekyung swallowed the blood on his tongue and raised his head. Two welcome faces were waiting for him.

"Ha."

At the laugh that escaped him, the Skeleton King turned to Magic Johnson with a stiff expression.

"Why's that ugly bastard grinning like that? Has he finally lost his mind?"

"Quit saying stupid things and shut your mouth. Hey, Jin. Can you hear me?"

"Human. How many fingers am I holding up?"

Jin Taekyung answered weakly.

"I can hear you fine. And I can see your finger."

"Tell me how many, you ugly, dim-witted bastard."

"One. But if you don't want me to break it, quit waving it around and lower it."

The Skeleton King, who had been waggling his middle finger in front of Jin's face, nodded.

"Good. You're still sane."

Jin Taekyung snorted, then broke into a cough.

“Team Leader Choi… *cough*, how is he?”

“He’s fine. A little injured, but fine.”

“Really? You’re sure?”

“Trust me. I’m not lying.”

Jin Taekyung let out a relieved sigh and straightened his back with effort.

He was still short of breath, his senses still dull. But he couldn’t stop here.

“Johnson.”

Sometimes a small gesture or a single word said everything.

Magic Johnson sensed what lay behind that brief call.

“No.”

“I have to go. You know that.”

“I do.”

Magic Johnson’s expression hardened.

“And I know you need to rest.”

The Grand Mage could see Jin Taekyung’s condition clearly. He was already at his limit, staying conscious through sheer force of will.

But recklessness belonged to the young.

It always had with the young man before him.

“Use Teleport magic.”

“Damn it, Jin. Are you crazy?”

“This isn’t a request.”

“Then as of this moment, I’m leaving the World Hunter Federation.”

“Then leave.”

Looking up at Magic Johnson, who was a head taller than him, Jin Taekyung continued:

“But until I accept your resignation, you’ll have to follow my orders.”

“…!”

“Come on, Johnson.”

Magic Johnson found himself at a loss for words.

The talk of resignations and orders was nothing more than a clumsy play on words. But there was nothing false about the resolve in Jin Taekyung’s eyes, or the sense of duty keeping his fading consciousness intact.

Damn it.

He couldn’t bring himself to meet those eyes. He was ashamed of himself for having to make this choice.

He squeezed his eyes shut, then opened them and gritted his teeth.

"…This is insane. Teleporting with the magical power concentration this high is practically suicide."

Jin Taekyung gave a faint smile.

"That takes me back."

"What?"

"Sichuan, China. You said the same thing there. And we pulled it off just fine."

"…!"

"Send me to the place the Prophet—no, the Doppelganger—told us about at the beginning."

Magic Johnson's pupils trembled as he looked at Jin Taekyung.

He had to stop him. He absolutely had to stop him.

But his damned Grand Mage's mind was already calculating, already drawing a reasonable conclusion.

There's a good chance it'll work.

They had tried Teleport magic once before under a magical power concentration like this, during the battle against the Arch Lich.

It had been possible because Magic Johnson was among the finest mages alive—and because the person he was transporting was Jin Taekyung.

If it isn't Teleport magic, if it isn't Jin… no one else can stop the Doppelganger.

Jin Taekyung's proposal was reckless, but the reality behind it could not be ignored.

A considerable amount of time had passed since the Doppelganger fled the battlefield. Catching up to it was almost impossible.

But if they used Teleport magic—

And if there was someone who could endure Teleport magic this dangerous, things would be different.

How cruel.

"Fuck."

Magic Johnson muttered a curse weakly. Jin Taekyung was standing on his own now, without anyone's help, looking straight at him.

And beside Jin stood someone who had volunteered to share the danger.

"I'm going with him. You stay and protect this place."

The Skeleton King. Lord of the undead, who had overcome even death.

The moment Magic Johnson saw him, he knew he had nowhere left to retreat.

"Promise me one thing."

Whummm.

The staff, filled with mana, trembled. Beyond the dazzling flash, his voice rang out faintly.

“Come back alive. No matter what.”

Fwoooosh.

An overwhelming flash of light swallowed the space around them.

Chapter 824

When dawn comes, the darkness retreats.

It was as natural as water flowing downhill. But to those fleeing a pursuer, daylight was hardly welcome.

Especially when that pursuer was a monster they could scarcely believe was human.

Already?

The Doppelganger bit its lip as it watched the sky slowly brighten.

Dawn had come too soon. No—it had taken longer than expected.

Everything should have been over before daybreak at the latest.

The Doppelganger knew that no amount of regret would change what had happened. Its carefully laid plans had gone awry long ago, and at the center of it all, from the very beginning, was that bastard.

Jin Taekyung.

A throb ran through its body. Just thinking of his name brought stabbing pain to one place after another.

The Doppelganger had died at Jin Taekyung's hands hundreds of times. It shuddered at the memory of his terrifying power.

I should never have approached him.

It had been a mistake. Greed.

After absorbing Yamamoto Genji, it should have hurried away—or never revealed itself in the first place.

I only needed a little more. Just a little.

The other humans had been its targets from the start: the many Hunters left in the rear. If it had absorbed their mana and life force, it could have achieved its goal.

Damn it.

But Jin Taekyung hadn't let the Doppelganger go. He had treated it like a slave, never allowing it out of his sight.

That was the Doppelganger's misfortune—and every other Hunter's good fortune.

If it had escaped Jin Taekyung's grasp, put on Yamamoto Genji's skin, and gone to the main force in the rear… it would have led countless monsters and fanatics into the desert and stained it red with blood.

Instead, the opposite had happened.

The monster army had been crushed, and the fanatics it had spent so much effort raising had become a shield for its escape.

I can't believe I got beaten this badly.

A bitter taste filled the Doppelganger's mouth.

It had lost a force tens of thousands strong. Their might aside, what it regretted most was losing a private army that obeyed its every command.

Still, I confirmed he's the Chosen One… Master will be pleased.

The Doppelganger shook its head at the thought of its master, whose intentions and true nature it could never fathom.

For decades, it had manipulated the world in secret from behind an unseen curtain. Yet before its master, even it was nothing more than a lowly servant.

Just like the foolish humans following it now.

"Are we still far?"

At the question, delivered with deliberate gravity, the man in black carrying it answered. Black cloth and a turban covered him from head to toe.

"We will arrive shortly, O great Prophet."

"You're too slow. At this rate, we may be caught. Go faster."

"Caught?"

"Yes. He's more of a monster than I thought. There's no telling what he might do."

At the Doppelganger's words, laced with an unusual mixture of impatience and fear, the dozens of men in black running around it like an escort exchanged glances.

They'd been running at full speed for nearly an hour. And now it wanted them to go even faster?

The man carrying the Doppelganger to conserve its strength glanced back at it before speaking carefully.

"I'm sorry to say this, but… we cannot go any faster."

"What?"

"Forgive our shortcomings, O Prophet."

His feet kept moving even as he spoke.

The Doppelganger stared at the back of the fanatic's head. Then it spoke.

"I see. This is my fault. I urged you on without considering how hard you're already pushing yourselves."

"We are unworthy of such words. Please, take them back."

"No. How could I fail to understand your hearts? It cannot have been easy to leave the battlefield while the brothers and sisters you grew up with remained behind."

"That…"

"And you must have struggled to accept why we had to flee like this, pursued by those evil heretics. Am I right?"

The eyes visible beneath the men's turbans wavered.

Every word struck home, as though the Doppelganger could see straight into their hearts.

Amir, their leader, had raised them to serve as the Prophet's personal guard. But the Promised Land they had all longed for had proved to be a barren canyon. Instead of green life and hope, heretics had awaited them there.

Then came the fierce battle, and their brothers and sisters fell, their blood spraying across the ground.

Even so, they had not faltered. They believed they were fighting a holy war to uphold God's will. They believed their brothers' and sisters' deaths were holy martyrdom.

At least, they had believed it until the Prophet they revered appeared in a wretched state and left the battlefield.

Was this really the right choice?

Escorting him west across desert and wilderness, they had passed oases without stopping. As they ran, a question that had flickered through their minds grew harder to ignore.

God was omniscient and omnipotent. The Prophet was a great seer.

Then why were they running? Why had they abandoned the battlefield like cowards to flee a force of heretics less than a tenth their size?

They tried to suppress their doubts with the faith they had built over a lifetime. But the questions they could not quite bury kept rising.

At last, they became words.

"To be honest, I don't understand."

The Prophet on the man's back gave no answer.

Taking his silence as permission, the man continued cautiously. Their destination had finally come into view in the distance.

"If we stood and fought, we could win. Haven't you always told us God is with us? That victory and glory would always be ours?"

Whoooosh.

Wind roared around the figures racing forward. Other men in black joined in.

"We abandoned our brothers and sisters and ran."

"We're afraid God will abandon us."

"O Prophet, may we ask what the Almighty told you?"

That was when the Prophet—no, the Doppelganger, which had listened in silence—spoke.

"Stop."

The men in black halted for the first time since they had set out.

Its strength restored while it rode on the man's back, the Doppelganger set its feet on the ground and murmured, "We've finally arrived."

The place was desolate.

No trace remained of what had once been said to be the world's second-largest oil field. Bones of unknown origin lay scattered across ground where not a blade of grass grew.

A land of death.

The thought came to the men in black as they took in the sight. One found the courage to ask, "Where are we?"

The others wanted to know just as badly. Mere servants, they had followed orders without daring to guess the great Prophet's purpose.

At his answer, their eyes flew wide.

"During the time of tribulation known as the Great Cataclysm, He stayed upon this land for a while."

"…!"

"…!"

"My master. The master of all creation. He told me, 'Go to the humans. Wait there until the time comes.'"

For a moment, the air seemed to stand still.

The men in black stared around them, dazed. Then they dropped to their knees as one and cried out.

"Ooh, oooooh…!"

"Inshallah!"[3261]

"God is great!"

Their reaction was only natural.

The Prophet served only one person, and this was the land where that person had once descended. It was worthy of being called the Sacred Land.

They prostrated themselves, crying out for God's blessing. Above their heads, the Prophet's voice continued.

"You said you feared God would abandon you."

His tone was gentle, as though soothing a fretful child.

"You wanted to hear what He told me."

His hand brushed the hair of the worshipers bowing upon the Sacred Land. His touch was warm, like a hand tending the painful wound of a groaning patient.

"Then I'll tell you."

But the gaze he turned on them was neither gentle nor warm.

The change was as stark as desert sunlight turning to a freezing northern blizzard. His voice had gone cold.

"How utterly worthless you are."

At that moment—

[3261] *Inshallah* is an Arabic expression meaning "if God wills."

Boom! Thud-thud.

The men in black blinked, still overcome with emotion.

When they raised their heads from the ground, red blood and pieces of flesh were scattered all around them.

“Huh…?”

A dazed sound escaped someone’s lips.

It was a pure question—and a reality they couldn’t accept.

Before they could find an answer, deep darkness fell over them.

Whoooosh.

A chill ran down their spines. Their hands and feet stiffened like stone, beyond their control.

Bodies honed through a lifetime of training, mana, the swords at their waists—none of it was any use now.

Ah.

A single groan.

Seized by a terror and shock unlike anything they had ever known, the men in black stared at the darkness bearing down on them.

The darkness was as smooth as a mirror, and their faces were reflected in it, clear as day.

This is…

Their voices failed them. Their bodies would not move.

Unable even to scream, they shifted their eyes. Above the darkness enveloping them, they saw a face.

The great Prophet who would lead them all to the Promised Land.

No. The *thing* they had believed was the Prophet looked down at them and smiled.

It was leading them not to death, or anything else, but into a bottomless pit within a dreadful abyss.

“Listen, you fools. You weak, worthless humans.”

Fwoooosh.

The darkness drained away their living vitality. Dozens of pale souls flowed into it, drawn toward the being within as if entranced.

“There is only one king in this world.”

The darkness swallowed the blood spilling from the seven openings in their faces. Taut skin shriveled. Bones crumbled.

Death drew near. Or perhaps it was the abyss.

As their vision plunged into that bottomless pit, they heard the devil’s final words.

“God…”

Had already abandoned you.

The words echoed faintly.

That was the end.

Where the darkness had fallen, twenty mummified corpses remained, kneeling as though in worship.

And there was only the being that had taken new life, as it had for hundreds of years.

Or so it thought.

Fwoooosh.

That was, until a dazzling beam of light erupted in the air above the ruins.

Until blue-white flames surged and poured forth from within that distant radiance.

Kwaaaaaang!

The mighty flames painted the Doppelganger’s eyes blue.

Chapter 825

A blinding flash erupted with the Teleport spell.

That was how it began.

The space around me warped. A terrible pressure unlike anything I'd ever felt seized my heart, and my joints and muscles screamed as they were pulled into a third void.

Hngh.

I couldn't breathe. It hurt.

Those few seconds felt like days.

But I clung to the thread of consciousness that was about to snap.

Crack.

I had to endure. I had to hold on.

I clenched my teeth around that single thought. Through the dazzling light flooding my vision, the ground and sky flipped past without end.

A vast wilderness. A desert leading toward hills curved like a crescent moon.

Hundreds of kilometers[3262] vanished in an instant, and the violently churning light began to fade.

At last, deep darkness settled over us.

Fwoosh.

Space split open. Through the gap seeped a new light, different from the flash moments ago.

And the light wasn't the only thing that had changed.

This is…

I could see it. Feel it.

Dim light, neither dark nor bright. The damp air of early morning.

Grains of sand carried on the wind. And beneath it all, the sticky, unpleasant sensation that belonged only to magical power.

We did it.

I knew it instinctively.

The dangerous attempt had succeeded. The Grand Mage's Teleport spell had pushed through the interference of magical power and brought us to the chosen coordinates.

And beyond the unfamiliar space we'd finally reached was the being we'd searched for so desperately.

The Doppelganger.

"…!"

[3262] Hundreds of kilometers is roughly 200–900 km, or about 120–560 mi.

Our eyes met in midair. Both of us stared wide-eyed.

I looked at the Doppelganger, and the Doppelganger looked at me.

Time slowed as if the world had stopped.

But my body already knew what it had to do. It moved, defying time and space.

Whoosh.

Wind split around the spearhead and brushed past my ears.

I drew back White Flame's shaft, clenched tight in my hand. Bones shifted out of place with a crack, and unexpected pain surged through me.

Crack.

An aftereffect of the unstable Teleport spell.

The Doppelganger's Blink spell had carried it only a few hundred meters.[3263] This attempt had taken us hundreds of kilometers,[3264] and my body had to pay the price.

Fuck.

My breath caught. My fingertips trembled. The Scorching Yang Qi racing along the spearhead faltered, as if it too sensed something wrong with my body.

But I had nothing to worry about.

I wasn't alone.

Thump.

A firm hand pressed against my back with tremendous force. The Skeleton King's clear voice reached my ear.

"Go."

In that instant—

Whoom!

I shot forward.

I tore through the gap opened by the Teleport spell and plunged down like lightning. The Scorching Yang Qi surged back to life like wildfire, coiling around the spearhead.

Fwoosh.

Heat spread outward. Ten-odd meters[3265] vanished in an instant.

And at the end of it stood the Doppelganger, eyes wide at this unexpected turn of events.

"Y—!"

What had it been trying to say? What had it wanted to say so badly?

No one—not even the Doppelganger itself—would hear the rest.

It couldn't finish.

[3263] A few hundred meters is roughly 200–500 m, or about 660–1,640 ft.

[3264] Hundreds of kilometers is roughly 200–900 km, or about 120–560 mi.

[3265] Ten-odd meters is roughly 10–19 m, or about 33–62 ft.

KWA-BOOM!

Blue-white flames erupted like a wave, swallowing its body and its unfinished cry.

The Doppelganger writhed.

Of all the countless deaths it had suffered, this was among the most agonizing. This was a true inferno.

Shhk. Fwoosh.

The spearhead had slashed diagonally across its upper body. In its wake, a lava-like force seeped into every part of it and raged there.

It kept devouring the life force that replaced each life lost to death.

It vaporized blood and melted flesh and bone.

“GRAAAAH!”

The Doppelganger screamed in agony.

The flames inside its body had already burned through more than ten lives. If its flesh and bones hadn’t kept regenerating to smother them, it would still be dying at that very moment.

“Grrr…”

Burst blood vessels stained its eyes red.

The Doppelganger groaned and straightened up.

Whizz—thunk!

Before it could steady itself, something flew in and pierced its forehead.

It revived before its falling body could hit the ground, then hurled itself to the side.

Thud-thud-thud!

White objects narrowly grazed its body and drove into the ground.

The Doppelganger recognized them as pieces of bone and looked up.

Something was rushing toward it, bearing a power at once utterly familiar and strangely alien.

That thing…!

The Skeleton King.

His sword flashed, imbued with power far beyond what a mere undead monster should possess—and far too great to ignore.

Shhk!

A sharp slicing sound.

Dazzling magical power, utterly at odds with the name **Hero’s Sword**, cut through the Doppelganger’s wrist.

It recoiled from the pain and snarled.

“How dare an undead like you…!”

Even in the Demon Realm, with its countless monsters, undead occupied the very bottom.

Unless they were like Liches, who chose to become undead only after reaching the highest realms, they were nothing but foot soldiers.

At least, that was how it was supposed to be.

Crack—splash!

Blood sprayed through a blinding flash of sword light.

The Doppelganger died again in an instant and clenched its teeth.

Damn it.

The exchange had been brief, but it could no longer deny the truth. The Skeleton King was no easy opponent.

The aberration before it had broken past the limits of ordinary undead and reached a higher level of existence.

But…

It's still no match for that monster.

The Doppelganger leapt back from the Skeleton King, its gaze shifting quickly.

Its sunken eyes found Jin Taekyung breathing hard, leaning on his spear like a cane.

He's different from the last time I saw him. He must have pushed himself beyond his limits, too.

The Doppelganger was no fool.

It was far more cunning than most humans or monsters. It had manipulated the world for decades from behind its puppet, Michael Silbert.

And when Jin Taekyung had appeared without warning and struck, it had swapped Siegfried Bassmann's soul for another.

Take hold.

KWA-AAH.

A fierce wind whipped around the Doppelganger. Sensing the ominous aura, the Skeleton King kicked off the ground and thrust out his hand.

Whoosh!

Pieces of his arm bone cut through the air with a sharp whistle. The white fragments flew like hidden weapons and lodged throughout the Doppelganger's body.

Or so the Skeleton King thought.

The figure that should have fallen in a spray of blood vanished as though it had never been there.

Pop.

Gone. In the blink of an eye.

That meant one thing.

Magic.

Blink?

Realization struck, and the Skeleton King twisted instinctively.

But the Doppelganger had already slipped from his sight and prepared its next move.

Grrrrk.

Mana surged through the slowing world.

At its center was the monster that had greedily swallowed everything the Grand Mage had possessed in life, absorbing it all for itself.

Air Slash.

And then—

Whoooosh!

Blades of wind rained down on the Skeleton King. Watching them, the Doppelganger was certain that even if the spell could not erase the aberration outright, it would put him out of the fight for a while.

That would be enough to end this wretched battle.

But it was wrong.

Just as the Skeleton King had lost sight of the Doppelganger for an instant, the Doppelganger had forgotten someone else.

Fwoosh.

Floating more than ten meters[3266] above the ground, it suddenly felt heat rising toward it.

Only then did it remember the man who, moments earlier, could barely keep his own body upright.

You've got to be fucking kidding me…!

The Doppelganger sucked in a startled breath and hurriedly drew back its mana.

Whoosh.

The gale descending on the Skeleton King dissolved into a gentle breeze. At the same time, layer upon layer of translucent barriers covered the Doppelganger's body.

Then, just as a dazzling flash shot across the space and finally struck the surface of the shields—

Crack!

The Doppelganger heard it. Saw it.

A single streak of flame bored through dozens of layers of Shield magic, shattering the barriers of mana.

KWA-BOOM!

[3266] Ten-odd meters is roughly 10–19 m, or about 33–62 ft.

Ignition. Shattering. Explosion.

All three happened at once. Blue-white flames filled the air, and a massive shock wave lashed out in every direction.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

The Skeleton King felt the impact reach the ground. For an instant, he wondered if that strike had cost the Doppelganger one of its most precious souls.

But Jin Taekyung knew better.

Exhausted as he was, he had scraped together every last bit of strength for that strike. He knew better than anyone why the clear, familiar chime had not sounded.

Not yet. Not yet.

The bastard still had the Grand Mage's power and soul.

But his legs, which should already have driven him off the ground, would not move.

His depleted mental strength kept dragging his consciousness toward a bottomless pit. The dozens of movements and attack routes flashing through his mind were no more than things he could imagine doing.

All he had was a friend who could read his intent from a glance.

Bang!

Their eyes met for an instant across the open air.

That was enough. The Skeleton King read the look in Jin Taekyung's eyes and launched himself off the ground without hesitation.

Through the acrid smoke filling the air.

Toward the Doppelganger at the center of the explosion.

Tssssss!

Golden magical power surged along his blade.

The force was less than half of what it would normally have been, thanks to the aftermath of the reckless Teleport spell. But the dazzling sword light cut through the sky without hesitation.

It sliced through the thick smoke and shot toward the enemy beyond.

Shing!

A single streak of light.

At the end of that keen strike—

Shhk!

Crimson blood burst forth like a fountain.

My vision was slowly blurring, but I saw it clearly.

The Skeleton King's strike cutting through the air. And someone's arm shooting up through the blood.

He cut it off.

No doubt about it. That slender white arm belonged to the Doppelganger—or, more precisely, to the Grand Mage it had absorbed three years ago.

But no head fell. No scream came.

If I hadn't spotted where the Doppelganger had gone after vanishing from sight again, I might have shouted in frustration.

Instead, I swallowed my anger.

My voice came out exhausted and unfamiliar, as though it belonged to someone else.

"Are you a fucking lizard or something, you son of a bitch?"

I turned slowly. The Doppelganger stood in the middle of the ruins, blood pouring from its cleanly severed shoulder.

"Let's go for your head this time. Not an arm or a leg—your head. How's that?"

"I'm afraid that won't be possible."

Its face twisted like a Fiend's, the Doppelganger continued.

"I'll need the Grand Mage's soul for what comes next."

What?

Just as I was about to blurt out a question—

Vwoom.

An immense power pulsed around it.

No—the entire ruin shuddered like a living creature.

Chapter 826

That's how humans are.

There are billions of us, and each of us sees the world through our own standards, our own idea of what makes sense. Only when we witness something those standards can't account for do we feel true shock.

I'm no exception.

One day, I suddenly began traveling between two worlds. The unbelievable power of the System brought me this far. None of that changed how I reacted to the impossible.

I'd always been honest about my feelings. Sometimes I got so caught up in them that I forgot what I was supposed to do.

Like right now.

What… is that?

The question brought every thought in my head to a halt.

I stared at the sight unfolding before me, stunned.

And I wasn't alone.

"What the hell…"

Even the Skeleton King, who'd been about to charge the Doppelganger again, muttered in a daze. The golden magical power that had blazed along the Hero's Sword had already faded.

We felt a tremendous force flowing out from the Doppelganger. At the same time, a rumble rose from deep beneath the ruins at our feet.

Rumble. Rumble-rumble.

This is…

The sensation was familiar. But the rumble wasn't merely loud. There was something deeper, more fundamental to it.

If I had to put a word to it…

Resonance.

The thought sounded crazy even to me.

In Murim, a First Rate swordsman could make a sword ring in response to him. But this was earth. A barren wasteland where not a tree or weed grew. A ruin no one visited anymore.

And now this dead land—the ruins in every direction—was trembling as if it were responding to something.

It sounded just as crazy the second time I thought it.

If an idea hadn't flashed through my mind, I might have stood there wrestling with the question for a long time. But as usual, the answer was closer than I'd expected.

"Magic."

The word came out almost as a groan.

Boom!

The ruins, which had been pulsing with a deep, heartbeat-like rumble, rippled. At the same instant, a dazzling mass of light burst forth and washed over everything.

Fwoooosh!

The flash was blinding. The Teleport spell I'd experienced earlier couldn't compare.

I shut my eyes without hesitation and bent sideways. The spear shaft trembled in my tightening grip.

It's coming. It has to be.

An instinct carved into my bones long ago forced my exhausted body to move. I was ready to evade the Doppelganger's attack and counter its ambush.

My body and mind felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton.

But even if I died in the clash, I was certain the Doppelganger wouldn't come out of it unscathed.

One Strike.

Whoever fell, the fight would be decided in a single move.

I couldn't see the Skeleton King, but he was probably waiting for the Doppelganger with the same resolve.

Come on.

I steadied my breathing and sharpened my senses as far as I could.

My eyes stayed shut. I felt the air quiver and smelled the earth of the dead ruins. I could even sense the dazzling light slipping through my eyelids, brushing my retinas—then gradually fading.

The light… is fading?

Of course, my first question was *why*.

The flash had given the Doppelganger a perfect opening. But there wasn't even a hint of the ambush I'd expected. All that reached me was a voice I'd grown used to hearing.

"You're more timid than you look, Chosen One."

I bit my lip.

Was it trying to lure me into a trap, or had it simply let its guard down?

I had only an instant to wonder. My choice was clear.

I slowly opened my eyes. The Doppelganger stood before me, staring straight at me.

No—it wasn't just the Doppelganger. Everything around it had changed.

"…!"

"…!"

Over its shoulder, I saw the Skeleton King's eyes widen. Mine might have looked the same.

I had never imagined a sight like this.

This is…

"What do you think? Impressive, isn't it?"

The Doppelganger cut off the Skeleton King and swept both arms out with a flourish.

A ball of light floated up in the wake of its fingertips, illuminating the ruins—or rather, the space that had been ruins only moments ago.

"Consider it an honor. You're the first guests in this marvelous temple."

Its words were half truth, half lie.

The place certainly had everything it needed to be called a temple. But *grotesque* fit it far better than *marvelous*.

Naturally.

Everything I could see was grand and immense, as though modeled on a temple from mythology. Yet rotten plant roots wrapped around the towering pillars, and the ceiling shut out every last ray of sunlight.

The temple reminded me of the Doppelganger. It had copied the outer trappings of myth convincingly enough, but everything inside was rotten and dead.

The only things that looked as though they belonged in a myth were the enormous stone statues of monsters packed into the vast space, which measured hundreds of meters[3267] across.

"A masterpiece, wouldn't you say?"

I gave the Doppelganger no answer. I just watched it.

Its attitude had changed unmistakably. And the instinct I'd developed through countless fights told me its ease wasn't carelessness.

Composure.

It had regained the composure it had briefly lost.

But that wasn't merely because a new arm had grown from its empty shoulder, or because a temple full of monster statues had risen around us.

It came here for a reason.

I quietly extended my senses.

An unseen force stirred on every side. At the same time, something Magic Johnson had once mentioned in passing about Siegfried Bassmann came back to me.

"Bassmann was an excellent Grand Mage. He wasn't the War Mage I am, but no one was more eager to study, and he was especially good at using Magic Formations."

[3267] Hundreds of meters—roughly 200–900 m—is about 660–3,000 ft.

I already knew that much. I was also certain the Doppelganger, after spending so long absorbing souls and accumulating experience, had grown even stronger than the Grand Mage had been in life.

Three years.

A long time, depending on how you looked at it. Or a short one.

Either way, it was enough time for the Doppelganger to make preparations after taking the Grand Mage's power and soul.

"Hey."

The Doppelganger clicked its tongue as it watched me.

"When someone asks you a question, you should answer."

Vwoom.

A low hum resonated with its forceful words.

I exchanged a quick glance with the Skeleton King, then opened my mouth.

"Are you an idiot? I'm not answering because the thing asking isn't a person."

"Hmm. No respect for your elders. Siegfried Bassmann is quite a respected hero in this world, isn't he?"

"Sure. The Grand Mage I know is. But…"

I lowered my spearhead.

"A monster like you doesn't count, you bastard."

I didn't know what Siegfried Bassmann had been like in life. I'd never seen him or met him. All I knew came from textbooks and what other people had told me.

But listening to a bastard wearing someone else's shell mock me still left me disgusted.

Of course, I had another reason to show my hostility so openly: the Doppelganger would consider it a natural reaction.

Just a little longer. Just a little.

I'd lowered the spearhead I'd aimed at it, but another spear remained pointed at it in my mind.

Slowly, I drew in the qi around me. Quietly. Subtly enough that the Doppelganger wouldn't notice.

It was one of the things I'd learned when I discovered what my Middle Dantian could do.

I spent too much strength before I'd recovered from the Teleport spell. I need a little time.

The Skeleton King did, too. But being already dead put him in better shape than me. He was gradually absorbing the magical power scattered through the air, ready to take the Doppelganger's head the moment I gave the signal.

Meanwhile, the bastard kept talking.

“Monster. Right, that’s what I am. I’ve spent so many decades among humans that I sometimes forget.”

The Doppelganger scratched its chin.

“But there’s one thing I never forgot, no matter what happened. This place. The command my master gave me here.”

I stopped short despite myself.

The Doppelganger’s master.

The being who had planted it in this world, just as the Doppelganger had put Michael Silbert forward as its puppet.

“Don’t tell me…”

My voice trailed off. The question rising in my mind made my stomach churn.

As if it had seen right through me, the Doppelganger smiled gently.

“Shall I guess who you’re thinking of?”

Why did that smile make my heart sink?

I struggled to keep my voice even.

“Shut your mouth.”

“Why? Weren’t you curious?”

“I don’t care who it is. Even if…”

My mouth felt as though I’d swallowed a handful of sand. I steadied my breathing and forced out the rest in a hoarse voice.

“Even if your master is the Demon King Asmodeus.”

“…!”

The air trembled. I could feel the Skeleton King’s agitation from where I stood.

The Demon King.

Ruler of the monsters and master of the Demon Realm, that land of death no human had ever reached.

To humanity, the Demon King Asmodeus was the cause of calamity—and calamity itself. His arrival had changed human history, overturned civilization, and robbed countless people of those they held dear.

People like me.

Father.

A beloved face flashed before my eyes. The misfortune that struck my family had lasted only an instant, but the sorrow and longing lasted forever.

Maybe that was why something hot was boiling deep in my chest when I needed to be calmer than ever.

Why I wanted to rip the mouth off the bastard smiling in front of me—and, at the same time, wanted him to answer.

Crack.

My grip had tightened until my hand turned white.

I glared at the Doppelganger and spoke. No, I muttered the words like a promise to myself.

“He—the Demon King—is already dead.”

And at that moment, I saw it clearly.

The Doppelganger’s smile deepened. Then came the question, carrying a truth I couldn’t accept.

“Do you really think so?”

“…!”

Chapter 827

For a moment, it was as if the world had stopped.

I stared blankly at the Doppelganger's silent smile. In my frozen mind, the voice I'd heard moments ago played over and over.

Do you really think so?

I couldn't breathe.

I already understood what that question meant. But a deep, instinctive refusal surged up from my chest, and before I knew it, I was speaking.

"Don't spout that bullshit."

There was no way.

I knew it. Everyone in the world knew it.

The Demon King—Asmodeus—was already dead.

Near the end of the Great Cataclysm, on what would later be called Victory Day, humanity's hero fought the Demon King and finally brought down the calamity that had turned the whole world into a blazing inferno.

And a few hours later, a small life was born in a country on a peninsula surrounded by the sea on three sides.

That life stood here now.

"The Demon King died the day I was born. On Victory Day."

The hoarse voice escaping my lips sounded like someone else's. I pressed on, putting force into the words as if making a vow to myself.

"He was erased, and we won. That's all there is to it. That's the truth."

I was only standing there. Only moving my lips to speak. Yet I was short of breath, and every breath I let out tasted bitter, as if it carried poison.

Like the voice now burrowing into my ears.

"Yes. That, too, is true, Jin Taekyung. Chosen One."

The abyss-like Doppelganger looked at me and curled its lips. On the Grand Mage's stolen face, the smile was as sly and wicked as a serpent's.

"That is all you know. And to you, it is the truth."

Step.

It took a slow step toward me. Its footfall echoed through the vast, grotesque temple, mingling with its voice.

"But look at me."

Its eyes, dark and deep, swirled like the abyss as they fixed on me.

"Look at me, who merely watched while countless humans died, and while you wept for joy at your victory. I was there among you, carrying out the Great King's command."

"…!"

"Do you still not understand? My existence is proof. Proof that the truth you believe is a lie, and that another truth exists beyond your knowledge."

My vision blurred in an instant.

The massive pillars supporting the temple vanished from sight, along with the grotesque statues and the Skeleton King, whose lips were moving as if he were trying to say something.

There was only one presence.

The Doppelganger filled my vision, its image etched sharply into my eyes.

The Great Battle of Paris.

My mind reeled. Small puzzle pieces surfaced one by one, filling the empty spaces.

Long before the Demon King Asmodeus fell, the Doppelganger had already infiltrated this world.

Michael Silbert hadn't chosen the Doppelganger from the start.

The Doppelganger had chosen him.

The monster from another world had recognized a monster in this one. It had read the immense ambition curled up inside a human body of flesh and bone.

Why had the Doppelganger chosen Michael Silbert, of all people?

I already knew the answer.

Because merely existing in this world wasn't all it wanted.

The Doppelganger possessed a gift unlike any other. It could absorb not only a person's appearance and abilities, but even their memories, making them its own. Living out its life as a single human would have been easy.

But now I understood. Its infiltration of humanity hadn't been an act of betrayal or defection.

It had received an order.

An order from the master it served with its life: the Demon King Asmodeus.

What happened after that must have been just as I knew it.

The Doppelganger put Michael Silbert forward and used him to move the world.

The puppet that had made a name for itself at the Great Battle of Paris quietly grew in the shadow of Cheon Taemin, the sky above it. And the shadow controlling the puppet fed on someone's soul, out of sight.

For more than thirty years, the Doppelganger climbed the stairs, keeping the order it had received in mind.

Until the endless staircase came to an end.

Until the moment it had waited for arrived, and a tightly shut door appeared.

"Judging by your face, you're finally starting to understand."

The Doppelganger laughed and raised a hand.

Whoosh.

A lone sphere of light drifted through the sunless darkness and stopped at the far end of the vast temple.

Its hazy glow lit the enormous space—and the single throne beneath it.

That's…

The moment I saw the empty throne, I knew instinctively who this temple and that seat had been built for.

And what the seventy-two bizarre, hideous stone statues represented.

"The seventy-two commanders of the Demon Realm…"

The Skeleton King's words came out like a groan. The Doppelganger spread both arms toward the throne, its face alight with rapture.

"The Great King will surely return. Before long, He will come with the countless armies that follow Him."

"…!"

Every hair on my body stood on end. A chill crawled up my spine like a snake.

I didn't believe the Doppelganger. It was made of lies, through and through. For now, I couldn't be sure whether what it had told me was true or just another lie meant to shake me.

But…

If every word it said was true.

Then I already knew what I had to do.

Dynamite with a severed fuse won't explode. A locked door won't open without a key.

And in that sense, the Doppelganger was both the fuse and the key: the signal for a vast calamity about to unfold.

This was the only chance to stop the return of a being who would be a nightmare for humanity.

I'll kill it.

The clouds in my mind cleared. With that single thought, as inescapable as a duty, qi surged through my body.

Fwoooosh.

My vision went hazy. My body, still bearing the full strain of the reckless Teleport spell, cried out in pain.

But I didn't hesitate. I drew Scorching Yang Qi from my Lower Dantian and sent it flooding through my limbs and acupoints, dulling the pain, forcing life back into my torn muscles—

Then I unleashed it.

BOOM!

Flamefire Path.

Blue-white flames burst from my toes and devoured the darkness.

In an instant split into ever smaller pieces, I erased the space between us and thrust my spear. It was a motion I'd repeated thousands, tens of thousands of times.

Toward a single being.

SHWAAA!

True to its name, White Flame cut through the darkness, its spearhead dazzling as a white flame.

As if nothing could stop it.

As if it would turn everything to ash.

At least, that was how it looked until the Doppelganger gestured and something invisible barred its path.

BOOM!

A deafening impact left my ears ringing. The force of the collision drove back against me.

Hngh.

I tightened my grip on the vibrating spear shaft.

Only ten paces away, the Doppelganger's smiling face wavered behind a transparent barrier.

"Do you understand now why I came all the way here?"

Shield magic?

No. This wasn't ordinary Shield magic.

Even as a Grand Mage, the Doppelganger could hardly have conjured a shield strong enough to stop my strike so easily in an instant.

Unless—

A Magic Formation.

Siegfried Bassmann.

One of only three Grand Mages in the world, and considered the finest master of Magic Formations among them.

The Doppelganger had absorbed his soul. And it had been given three years.

"You son of a…"

"You humans take out insurance. Think of this as something similar."

Confidence showed in its curled lips. It hadn't smiled like that while fleeing from me, dying again and again.

"Don't waste your effort. I'm the master here."

Vwoom.

An unprecedented force resonated from every direction.

Magic Formations blazed into view all around us, and the enormous statues depicting the seventy-two commanders of the Demon Realm began to tremble.

"As the Great King's representative, I command you: awaken from your slumber."

Crackle.

Stone fragments fell on every side as the Doppelganger's command rang out.

The statues, which had seemed destined to stand motionless forever, began to move.

No—they opened their eyes.

Flash.

Monsters, ranging from a few meters to dozens of meters[3268] tall, gazed down at the distant ground with glowing red eyes.

The Skeleton King, whose earlier attack had been stopped by a translucent barrier just like mine, stared at them.

Then he shouted like a bolt of lightning.

"Dodge!"

At that moment—

WHOOOOM!

Arms, legs, and claws of stone filled my vision as they came crashing down.

The world slowed, and my breath stretched out.

No. I can't dodge.

Not because the statues' attacks were too powerful or too fast.

Because every step I took away from them would take me farther from the Doppelganger.

Now's the time to go.

The statues under its control were powerful. But it had copied only the forms of the Demon Realm's seventy-two commanders. Not one of them had the strength of an S-rank monster.

In that case—

I'll cut them down.

My body moved with the thought.

No. My body wasn't the only thing that moved.

Vwooooooom.

With a powerful hum, my closed Middle Dantian opened.

A space pitifully small beside the vast temple—but large enough for what I needed—fell under my control.

Hngh.

A headache so sharp it nearly blacked out my vision.

I endured it. I had to.

I clenched my teeth until my lips were ragged, then let go of White Flame's shaft.

[3268] A meter is about 3.28 ft. A few meters is roughly 7–16 ft; dozens of meters is roughly 66 ft or more.

Fwoosh.

Hot. Blinding.

The spear blazed blue-white with Scorching Yang Qi drawn from my Lower Dantian. The will of my Middle Dantian moved it.

No—it sent it whirling.

SHWAAAA!

I heard no roar. In a world filled only with the sound of air being torn apart, a streak of light-flames cut through everything around it.

SHWAK!

Through space.

SHHK!

Through the soulless Golems, as if it had only grazed them.

Again and again. Perhaps dozens of times.

At last, after tearing through everything on every side, the spear returned to its master. I caught it.

KWA-AAAA!

Everything came crashing down.

All seventy-two colossal statues. The pillars as thick as the World Tree.

And the countless Magic Formations that had filled every corner of the temple.

KWA-CRASH!

Maybe my body had been pushed past its limit.

My vision turned white. I couldn’t see a thing.

But I could hear. I could feel.

The mana and magical power breaking apart. And beyond them, one presence struck with shock.

“Say that again.”

The words came out in a voice that sounded ready to give out. I drew on the last of my strength and stepped forward.

Step.

“Who exactly is the master here?”

At that moment, instead of an answer, a dazzling radiance filled the temple.

Chapter 828

Fear comes in different kinds and degrees.

Some people spend their whole lives afraid of water because they fell into a valley stream as children. Those who've lived through an earthquake carry trauma like a brand.

But the greatest, deepest fear is fear of the unknown.

A realm no one has ever seen—or even imagined.

That is the unknown.

The universe. The deep sea. Places even humanity, which built a brilliant civilization through science and magic, has yet to fully reach.

And now, in this very moment, a single streak of fire tearing everything around it to shreds.

BOOOOM!

It was like a storm.

A storm of fire, so sharp it made your skin crawl, turning everything it touched to ash.

The Doppelganger stared, stunned.

Blue-white flames poured out suffocating heat, tinting its pupils red.

SHWAAK!

Tear. Cleave. Cut.

The wind shrieked. The Golems it had spent three years painstakingly shaping burst apart like fireworks.

Limbs made of massive, solid rock were no use. Neither were weapons brought down hard enough to split the earth.

Fwoosh. KRRRACK!

They melted. They broke apart.

In an instant, all seventy-two Golems became heaps of rubble—before the Doppelganger could order them to retreat.

No. It hadn't even had time to give the order.

The flames tearing through everything hadn't destroyed only the Golems.

CRASH!

An immense force shook the air.

The magic circles, scattering dazzling halos of light, exploded one after another.

The Doppelganger watched in horror as the translucent barrier around it melted like candle wax.

"What the…"

Before it could finish, something hot surged up from deep inside its body and spilled through its throat into its mouth.

Hack.

The Doppelganger coughed up a clump of dark red blood. Its pupils trembled.

Knowledge from Siegfried Bassmann's memories struck its empty mind.

Mana backlash.

Its connection to countless magic circles had been forcibly severed, sending the energy throughout its body into turmoil.

If it had cast the magic directly instead of preparing the circles through various conduits and spells, the backlash would have been severe enough to kill it several times over.

How? How is this possible?

The Doppelganger raised its head, gasping for breath.

No trace of composure remained in its shocked eyes. Reflected in them was a human who seemed as unknowable as the unknown itself.

Jin Taekyung.

There he stood, gripping a silver spear that shone white as the Golems' remains rained down over his head.

Through the lingering light of the magic circles melted by the flames, the Doppelganger saw him staring back.

A predator.

"Say that again."

His voice sounded ready to give out, yet it seethed like lava as it reached the Doppelganger's ears.

He staggered toward it as if he might collapse at any moment.

Step.

It was strange.

The whole place was filled with thunderous noise. The temple, stripped of its pillars, was slowly collapsing, and the rocks that had once been Golems were scattering in every direction…

Step.

Yet that small human's footsteps sounded like thunder. His next words made every hair on the Doppelganger's body stand on end.

"Who exactly is the master here?"

"…!"

The Doppelganger swallowed a scream before it could escape its lips.

Fear showed plainly in its eyes as it stared at Jin Taekyung.

A monster. That human was a monster.

One who exceeded every expectation, every limit, by an impossible margin.

After dying countless times on the battlefield, the Doppelganger had abandoned its contempt for Jin Taekyung. It had set everything else aside and judged the situation coldly. This time, it had been certain.

Once it reached its destination, everything would go smoothly.

Jin Taekyung would never catch it.

But it had been wrong.

The Doppelganger, which had left the battlefield before anyone else, hadn't known Jin Taekyung had reached an even higher realm in that brief time.

Now that it understood, it was too late.

If I waste even a little more time here… I'm finished.

Erasure. Forever.

Cold fear crawled up its spine. What it did next came from instinct rather than reason.

The Doppelganger burned through the souls it had left without hesitation. It healed the body mangled by mana backlash, then gathered the energy that had once again filled it to the brim into both hands and unleashed it.

At the inhuman monster approaching it.

At Jin Taekyung.

FWOOSH!

The instant a blinding flash burst forth—

"No!"

A step ahead of Jin Taekyung, the Skeleton King had been charging toward the Doppelganger. He twisted sharply and threw himself in front of the flash.

POP!

The Skeleton King in his usual state wouldn't even have snorted at it.

For all his bluster, he acknowledged that Jin Taekyung was stronger than he was.

But…

Right now, I'm the only one who can protect that devious human.

He would protect him, even if it put him in danger.

At some point, that had become the most natural thing in the world to the Skeleton King.

Why?

He'd stopped asking himself. Friends didn't need a reason.

SHWAA!

The Skeleton King brought down the Hero's Sword.

Golden magical power, bright as sunlight and strangely unlike magic, split the flash.

No.

Just as he thought he'd cut through it, the flash passed through the blade like mist and swelled like a balloon.

WHUM.

What the—

Before he could finish the thought, a light far brighter than the first filled his vision.

FWOOSH!

The whole world turned white.

In that blinding flash, which would have instantly robbed an ordinary human of their sight, the Skeleton King belatedly remembered the answer to his question.

Damn it.

There was no doubt.

This was Light magic, a spell even lower- and mid-level mages could cast with ease.

A simple convenience spell. Its light was faint and it had little killing power, so it was almost never used in combat.

At least, that was what the Skeleton King knew. It was accepted as fact among Hunters, too.

If he'd known that Siegfried Bassmann, a scholarly Grand Mage, had shut himself away in his hideout to study countless spells—and had improved Light magic's power and usefulness by several levels—he could have dealt with it.

But it was too late. The mistake made the Skeleton King's heart sink.

I can't see. Anything.

He hadn't lost his sight completely.

The Skeleton King was undead. His vitality far exceeded that of a human made of flesh and blood.

But even a moment without sight was a mistake he couldn't take back when he was fighting an enemy as dangerous as the Doppelganger and trying to protect someone else.

It planned this from the start. It knew I'd step in…

In the blank white world, the Skeleton King raised his sword. With his sight gone, his hearing took in everything around him.

The roar of rubble crashing down a moment later.

An unfamiliar cracking sound from high above.

And then…

A low voice no one else could hear reached his ear.

—Don't let it get away.

"…!"

At Jin Taekyung's Sound Transmission, the Skeleton King understood.

Why no magic had come flying at him, even though this was the perfect chance to knock him down.

And what the energy moving stealthily through the air was.

Teleport!

The Skeleton King's guess was right.

The Doppelganger was pouring all its strength into drawing a Teleport magic circle.

It felt both relief and regret that it had taken the soul of such an accomplished Grand Mage.

You piece of shit…!

The Doppelganger's nature might be that of a monster familiar with magical power, but right now it was in the body of an ordinary human.

If it tried to cast Teleport without a magic circle to get as far as possible from that inhuman monster, Jin Taekyung, it would crumble to dust without even a chance to resurrect.

Fwoosh.

Mana flowed from the Doppelganger's hand as it swept through the air, slowly wrapping around its body.

The magic circle would take a little time to complete, but it would reduce the danger by more than half.

Instead of disintegrating without a trace, it might manage to save its upper body.

That was enough for the Doppelganger to survive. The ancient monster of the abyss had no intention of letting anyone interfere with a matter on which its continued existence depended.

Whoosh. CLANG!

It happened in an instant.

A bone fragment shot in with a sharp whistle and was deflected by the defensive magic the Doppelganger hurriedly cast.

SH-SH-SH-SH! CLANG!

With the magic circle nearly complete, the Doppelganger grimaced at the Skeleton King, who kept firing bone fragments without pause.

What? The effect should last much longer.

According to the Grand Mage's memories, the spell had been perfect. It had struck precisely at a weakness and robbed the Skeleton King of his sight.

Losing your sight in battle was like losing the use of both legs.

That was why the Doppelganger hadn't tried to disable him any further. The Skeleton King was a formidable opponent, and getting far away from Jin Taekyung —who might do anything next—was more urgent.

But right now, the Skeleton King's movements were far beyond anything the Doppelganger had expected.

CRASH!

Fired with great speed and force, and aimed with extraordinary precision, the bone fragments finally shattered its defensive magic.

The Doppelganger escaped through the opening with a Blink spell, confusion filling its eyes.

How the hell…

It could tell from every move the Skeleton King made. Those attacks required certainty.

Even though the Skeleton King had taken the full force of the Light magic, he continued his attacks without the slightest hesitation.

POP.

His hazy form shot across the space. At the same time, the golden magical power coating his sword traced a graceful arc.

As its wielder intended.

And as the voice at his ear directed.

—One step left.

At that moment—

SHWAAK!

The Skeleton King's unhesitating charge wavered.

An ice spear shot past between his streaming golden locks and slammed into a pile of rubble.

BOOM! CRACK-CRACK!

The air turned cold. The Skeleton King moved by his own senses and the Sound Transmissions reaching his ear.

—Three steps right. A horizontal slash.

SHHK!

Binding magic summoned vines to restrain its target. Stems as thick and tough as chains were severed in a single stroke.

—Duck.

Dozens of Magic Missiles tore through empty air.

—Ten steps forward. Run it through.

BOOM-BOOM-BOOM!

As expected of spells cast with a Grand Mage's power, they struck hard and exploded spectacularly.

But not a single spell touched the Skeleton King. The Doppelganger swallowed a startled breath as he closed to within ten steps.

Already…!

It felt as though a ghost had bewitched it.

The Skeleton King kept firing bone fragments to disrupt the magic circle. He dodged or cut through every attack spell it cast.

Was that mutant always this strong?

But the question disappeared without a trace the moment the Doppelganger saw the Skeleton King's unfocused eyes.

A shock like a bucket of cold water took its place.

It was him. From the start.

What had Jin Taekyung done?

How could he be barely standing, as if he were about to collapse at any moment, and still render the Doppelganger this helpless?

Confusion and fear gripped it as it gathered its mana.

Blink magic.

That instant flicker put distance between it and the Skeleton King once more.

Or so it thought.

It would have, if a voice hadn't reached the Skeleton King before the spell took effect—before several meters[3269] of space vanished.

—Five o'clock. Advance and…

Before the Doppelganger's form could blur, the Skeleton King changed direction and charged, lifting his sword.

Fwooooosh.

In a world gone slow, brilliant golden magical power rose like a wave.

The voice came again, and the sword cut through space.

—From the sky to the ends of the earth. Bring it down.

SHWAAK!

A golden flash split the monster of the abyss where, a moment earlier, there had been nothing but empty air.

SHHK. FWOOSH!

A red line ran from the crown of its head to its crotch.

Blood burst out. Then a Sound Transmission reached the Skeleton King's ear, sounding almost like a groan.

—Ah, shit. Right. My EXP.

[3269] Several meters is roughly 3–5 m (10–16 ft).

Chapter 829

The Doppelganger.

The Final Abyss, which had existed for hundreds of years, saw and felt everything as time slowed.

The Skeleton King charging toward it.

Blink magic to put distance between them.

And then…

SHWAK.

A soft rush of air reached its ears, and golden swordlight filled its vision.

It all happened—and ended—in an instant.

So quickly that the monster of the abyss, born in the deepest reaches of the Demon Realm, couldn’t even react.

Slice.

Hot.

The strike it could neither block nor dodge split the crown of its head. It carved through flesh and bone, devoured its organs and mana, and raced down to its crotch.

Like a bolt of lightning.

Ah.

The Doppelganger staggered backward with a silent sigh.

No—at the moment it felt itself take a step, it crumpled, spraying a fountain of blood.

SPURT!

Its blood-red view tilted slowly.

As the Doppelganger realized it had died, the bond that had held a soul tightly captive for three years was torn away.

Siegfried Bassmann.

The Doppelganger could feel it clearly.

The mana, memories, and carefully hoarded vitality of the Grand Mage once hailed as a hero were draining away like the tide.

The ticket for the last flight out of here had just sold out.

Splash.

Its body, split cleanly in two, fell into a pool of blood.

A death no one could deny.

And a resurrection that defied the natural order.

Pop!

Reborn with a new life and a new body, the Doppelganger threw itself forward without hesitation.

It had failed to escape with Teleport magic, but there was still a way out.

Get as far away as possible. Even if it costs every life I have left!

It had lived for hundreds of years.

Throughout that long life, it had survived by prostrating itself at the king's feet. It had been promised certain rewards when the coming day arrived.

The commanders of the Demon Realm's seventy-two legions? Even those arrogant, mighty beings could never hope to share in its glory.

Besides, many of them were already dead.

How it had laughed when it learned that Leviathan, one of those commanders, had been killed by Jin Taekyung.

But it couldn't die like a dog here. Not when it was destined to stand at the Great King's right hand.

I have to survive. I can't die here.

The Doppelganger ran with all its strength.

Toward an exit from the temple it had hidden in case of emergency.

Toward the countless glories waiting for it in the near future.

Only then did it realize.

At this very moment, only its lower half was running for its life.

Slice—

The delayed sound of the cut reached its ears.

The Doppelganger's already-severed upper half tilted in midair.

Its eyes grew distant as it watched its lower half run on, still moving with its original force, unaware that the body had been split apart.

"You son of a—"

SH-SH-SH-SH!

The rush of air swallowed its unfinished words.

As its upper half scattered into dozens of pieces, the Skeleton King's sword moved again.

Thrust!

"Ghk."

A stifled groan.

The Doppelganger writhed, reborn from one of those tiny pieces with a new body. It was hard to believe it had died so gruesomely only moments ago.

Even with its chest pierced, its bloodshot eyes remained fixed on the exit.

Damn it. Damn it!

The Doppelganger cursed soundlessly and regretted what it had done.

How many souls had it stolen from humans over the past thirty years? How many of those humans had been considered strong?

It didn't know. Even the Doppelganger couldn't count them all.

They had been little more than a harvest. Like a farmer gathering the eggs his hens laid each morning, the Doppelganger collected human souls and spent most of them without a second thought.

It hadn't mattered.

No matter how many it used up, it could simply replenish them. Even if it didn't, it had enough.

No—it had had more than enough.

Until today, when it met a monster wearing human skin.

Swish.

A cold breeze brushed its nape. A sharp blade cut through its neck, and death and rebirth arrived together.

No. They came again and again, like a record stuck on repeat.

Slice! Thrust! SH-SH-SH!

It was cut, stabbed, and broken into dozens of pieces that scattered through the air.

Each time, the Doppelganger died and came back as a man, a woman, or an old person. Drawing on the powers and memories it had stolen from them, it edged closer to the exit.

A hundred meters[3270] became dozens.[3271]

Dozens of meters became a few.[3272]

It threw away its lives one by one—lives that were no longer expendable, each one precious now.

I can't… I can't lose any more.

Fear rose with the word *Erasure*.

The lives that had once numbered around a thousand were gone.

Feeling its vitality dwindle until it could count what remained on both hands, the Doppelganger summoned every ounce of strength and stood up again.

Slide. WHOOSH!

Its body regenerated in an instant, like the beanstalk in an old fairy tale. Reborn in a grotesque way words couldn't explain, the Doppelganger hurriedly rolled aside.

Slash!

Pain like a burn raked down its back.

[3270] One hundred meters is about 328 ft.

[3271] Dozens of meters means tens of meters—roughly tens to hundreds of feet.

[3272] A few meters is roughly 7–16 ft.

But its desire to survive was stronger than the pain that lingered. As the Doppelganger threw itself forward, heedless of its life, the Skeleton King reached out without hesitation.

Thud-thud-thud!

The Doppelganger staggered and swallowed a surge of blood.

Something white jutted from the middle of its chest. Another bone fragment had pierced its calf and lodged deep in the ground.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

The Skeleton King’s low voice came from behind it, followed by a rush of wind.

Feeling him close in, the Doppelganger gritted its teeth. The bone fragment pinning its calf to the ground held as firmly as a stake.

Crack!

Though far weaker than the Skeleton King, its new body was still easily strong enough to belong to an A-rank Hunter.

The Doppelganger tore off its leg below the knee and moved the one leg it had left.

It summoned all its strength and kicked off the ground.

BOOM!

A deafening impact rang out, and a fierce wind swept over its body.

Its eyes burned with longing at the sight of the temple entrance, now right in front of it.

If I can just get out of here.

If I can somehow avoid Erasure…

I swear I’ll turn the world you tried to protect into ashes.

It reached toward the secret door that would open only for it.

SHWEEEE!

From somewhere far away—

CRUNCH!

A streak of light tore through space and swallowed the Doppelganger whole, ripping and smashing its body apart.

As its vision went black, a voice pierced its ears.

“You fucking bastard. You invite a guest over and then try to leave?”

How cold that voice sounded.

And how hot the flames bursting from the spearhead buried in its body.

Fwoosh.

ROOOAR!

The Doppelganger writhed in blue-white flames, its vision dyed blue and white, unable even to scream.

Until the body that had once belonged to someone else, and all the vitality within it, burned to ash.

Until every lie it had built up burned away, leaving a single truth behind.

Step. Step.

Whoosh.

Wind followed unsteady footsteps, scattering the ash.

A black, gray-white shadow stirred amid the thick layer that had settled on the ground.

"…So that's it."

Supported by the Skeleton King, Jin Taekyung stood before it. A faint light shone in his eyes as he looked down at the shadow.

He saw through to the one truth of a being made entirely of lies. To its pathetic essence.

> **System Level 10 Doppelganger**

"So this is all you were."

"…!"

The shadow—no, the Doppelganger—trembled.

Just standing there left me short of breath.

My senses were fading and my vision was blurring, but my racing heartbeat sounded as loud as thunder.

Thump. Thump-thump.

Was this the price of pouring all my strength into that final strike?

My whole body trembled. If the Skeleton King hadn't been supporting me, I would've collapsed already.

But I didn't fall.

I pushed back the sleep demon pressing in from every direction, pulled away from the Skeleton King, and stood on my own two feet.

Then I looked down.

At a shadow as small as a child, made of an evil purer than any child could ever be.

At the hideous being that was now nothing more than a shadow.

"Yeah. This was all you were."

I repeated the words I'd said earlier, almost to myself.

The Doppelganger trembled as if it were afraid. Looking at it, then at the Level window floating over its head, I nearly let out a hollow laugh.

> **System Level 10 Doppelganger**

Level 10.

That was all. Nothing more, nothing less.

For a Hunter, that was the very bottom of F-rank. For a Murim martial artist, it was a Third Rate swordsman who'd only just begun to sense internal energy.

That was the Doppelganger's essence, revealed by the *Truthful Eye*. Its origin. Its one and only truth.

All this, because of a thing like this…

I swallowed the rest and clenched my teeth.

When I closed my eyes, flames flickered in the darkness.

A city in ruins.

Bodies lay scattered among the smoke rising everywhere. The screams of those still alive rang in my ears.

How many people had died because of the Doppelganger's terrorist attacks and the monsters?

How many had lost their homes and had to say goodbye to their precious family and friends?

Hundreds of thousands? Millions?

I didn't know.

More than thirty years had passed since the Doppelganger slipped into this world. I couldn't even begin to guess what it had done behind the scenes.

Grind.

My fists tightened.

Blood seeped from the skin where my nails had dug deep. I opened my eyes, but none of it went away.

Not the ruined city. Not the emptiness in the dead people's eyes or the cries of those still alive.

I remembered it all. It was branded into my eyes and ears, impossible to erase.

And of all those things, only one was here before me.

Crush.

"Ghk. Guhh…"

My foot, charged with internal energy, pressed down on the shadow.

The Doppelganger, writhing and groaning, begged me for mercy. It could feel pain, even in this cursed form.

"S-save me…"

“Save you?”

“Y-yes. Anything. I’ll do anything! I will!”

For a moment, I just stared down at it. Then I gathered the internal energy I had left and sent it surging toward the tip of my foot.

Crack. Crunch!

“AAAGH!”

I watched the Doppelganger scream.

Then the Skeleton King placed a hand on my shoulder.

“Human.”

“What?”

I’d only asked a question, but when the Skeleton King saw my face, his lips moved quietly.

“…Nothing.”

What kind of face was I making? Did I look exhausted? Or was it twisted with a rage he’d never seen before?

Probably the latter.

The Doppelganger had stopped screaming the moment it saw my expression.

It spoke in a voice full of fear.

“I-I didn’t want to do it! Have you forgotten? It was all on the king’s orders!”

The king.

Demon King Asmodeus.

At the name that came to mind with its cry, the anger gripping my body and mind wavered.

Chapter 830

Master of the Demon Realm. Lord of the monsters.

Demon King Asmodeus.

How could I forget that name? The demon who was the beginning and the source of every catastrophe.

“I-I didn’t do it because I wanted to! Have you forgotten? The king ordered all of it!”

I looked down at the Doppelganger as it cried out in desperation. After a brief struggle with myself, I drew back the internal energy I’d been channeling into my foot.

“Cough—hack.”

The pressure on its chest lifted, and it broke into a fit of coughing.

The Doppelganger let out the breath it had been holding, then glared at me with eyes full of pain and fury. But deep inside them, fear lurked—fear it hadn’t quite managed to hide.

It looked so helpless that it was hard to believe it had been a Named Monster at Level 170.

Yet the little shadow before me was the Doppelganger’s essence. Its one and only truth.

It must have stolen countless lives to become so powerful.

It had taken whatever it could, absorbed it, digested it.

Those lives had fed it and served as steps on its climb to power.

But today, the feast it had enjoyed for so long was over.

The fanatics who worshiped it like a god were gone. So was its army of monsters. With no one at its side, only one path remained open to it.

“Spit it all out.”

Crick.

The thousand-geun[3273] pressure I’d lifted a moment ago bore down through the tip of my foot once more. I watched the Doppelganger stifle a groan, then continued quietly.

“What you know. And what’s about to happen.”

Demon King Asmodeus.

Evil itself. The source of it.

What I wanted from the Doppelganger was information about that accursed being—and about the future of this world.

“What you said just now.”

[3273] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is 600 kg (about 1,320 lb).

The hoarse voice that came from my mouth sounded like someone else's.

My mouth felt as though I'd swallowed a handful of sand. Exhaustion and thirst weren't the only reasons.

"He—the Demon King…"

Each syllable was a struggle. I didn't dare say it aloud, or even imagine it.

But I knew.

I knew what became of people who turned away from reality. I knew what lurked beyond the reality they tried so hard not to face.

To escape a forest fire, you first have to know it's there.

You have to see the rising smoke and the red flames, feel the heat that threatens to burn you alive.

Just as I was doing now.

"Is he still alive?"

In the suffocating silence, the patter of small stones falling from overhead sounded unusually loud.

I said nothing. Neither did the Skeleton King or the Doppelganger.

For a moment, none of us spoke.

Until I heard the whisper of a shadow, something not of this world.

"Is he still alive?"

Stir.

The darkness rippled. Its pitch-black face, its features barely discernible, split into a long grin.

"You know nothing, Chosen One. Foolish mortal. One day, time will break you, and you will crumble into dust."

The Doppelganger was laughing.

It had forgotten its anger, pain, and fear of me.

Or perhaps it had covered them all with the presence of its absent master.

"Our Great King overcame the curse of the gods. He may waver, but he will not break. Even if he perishes, he will rise again. And at last, he will make all the earth and water in this world his own."

"…!"

"That is the only truth. A truth you cannot stop, even now that you know it. Before long, it will become reality."

I stared blankly at the Doppelganger as it laughed aloud.

The moment I met its eyes, darkness swirling within them, my vision swam.

This is…

No sound came out. The dust and rubble around us vanished. So did the Skeleton King and the Doppelganger.

No. It felt as though my entire consciousness was being pulled somewhere.

At the same time, sights unlike anything I'd ever seen poured before my eyes like a meteor shower.

SHWAAAA…

A brilliant sun rose in the east, painting the world with light. Clouds raced across the blue sky. Sunset came, then the moon rose and darkness fell.

One day. Then another.

Time sped past like a scene from a nature documentary I'd once watched. But there was nothing beautiful about it.

BOOM!

A tremendous blaze erupted with a thunderous roar.

Wild animals scattered across the vast wilderness, all bolting at once as if on cue. Behind them, monsters advanced across the horizon with flames the color of sunset at their backs.

Rumble…

Hundreds of thousands. Millions.

Perhaps even more.

An army of monsters beyond counting poured in from every direction. They shook the earth and blotted out the sky.

Kyaaaaargh!

A terrible roar rang out from above the clouds.

Huge wings swept through them, blocking the sunlight. Then the shadow they cast fell over me.

Whoosh.

My view flipped. Sky and earth turned upside down.

In that inverted landscape, I saw a city burning.

BOOM!

Hundreds of cannons fired at once. Giants as tall as skyscrapers staggered, engulfed in flames, while figures shot like streaks of light through the ruined streets and charged at them.

Their weapons blazed with radiance. They shouted their resolve as if coughing up blood.

"Never retreat! Stand and fight!"

"For humanity!"

They were Hunters.

Humanity's sword and shield against those accursed beings.

Warriors given a sacred mission by someone unseen.

I couldn't move a finger. From high above, I watched their magnificent charge.

They fought monsters that outnumbered them dozens of times over. True to their cries, they never retreated. They shed their blood for humanity and fell.

Until the sun went down and the moon rose.

Until the last of them was gone.

All I could do was watch.

As if someone were controlling me, I saw Niagara Falls turn red with blood. I saw hundreds crushed to death beneath the shattered Leaning Tower of Pisa.

I was a consciousness without a body. Nothing more than a spectator.

There was nothing I could do.

As the scene changed without pause, my only right—and my curse—was to watch civilization burn to ash and hear the screams of the dying.

Death beyond counting. Destruction.

Corpses covered the streets. A broken church cross lay plunged into a pool of blood.

A child, unaware of what had happened to their parents, could no longer bear the hunger and crawled out of a small box. When the child saw a pack of goblins in the alley, the doll in their hand fell to the ground.

Catastrophe.

A word for an unexpected, unfortunate disaster.

But even that word, a symbol of the Great Cataclysm, could not begin to describe the horrors I had seen.

In place of the voice that wouldn’t come, one word suddenly occurred to me.

The end.

Yes. This was the end.

The civilization humanity had built over countless years lay in ruins, and not a scrap of hope remained in anyone’s heart.

More precisely, their hope was already dead.

One person at a time. Slowly.

Torn into hundreds or thousands of pieces, they disappeared into the bellies of hungry monsters.

“To Magic Johnson.”

A quiet voice carried across a vast plaza lit by countless flickering candles.

A face both familiar and unfamiliar.

Team Leader Choi, his face covered in scars and one arm gone, drained his glass.

Xiao Shen lifted a bottle with tearful eyes and filled the empty glass.

“To ‘Uncle Chuck’ Hagel and our friend Stone-King, who became eternal stars one year ago today.”

As I heard the names called out with every glass filled and drained, I understood.

This was a memorial for the fallen.

A send-off before battle, one last remembrance of the heroes who had gone ahead—the people who had been humanity's hope.

And…

"To the bravest man of all."

"To the light of humanity, who stood against the darkness and always lit the way for everyone."

I was nowhere to be seen.

"To Jin Taekyung…"

The trembling voice fell silent. Team Leader Choi drained yet another glass and clenched his fist.

Crack.

Blood ran from his hand, mingling with the shards of the shattered glass and dripping onto the ground. The candles went out all at once, and silence fell over the entire plaza.

At the same time, light swelled at Team Leader Choi's waist.

Fwoosh.

The Hero's Sword.

Cracked and broken though it was, its blade still held a keen edge. Brilliant light welled up along it, spreading across the candleless plaza and faintly illuminating the deep darkness.

Flap.

A powerful wind swept in from afar and whipped dozens of flags, large and small.

A crossed sword and shield. The design was crudely drawn, but I recognized it: the flag of the World Hunter Federation.

"There's nowhere left to retreat."

Thud. Thud-thud.

Thousands—perhaps tens of thousands—of feet stamped the ground. The light gathered on the Hero's Sword picked out their faces one by one.

"And we must not retreat."

Clang! Clang-clang!

Blades clashed in the air, spitting sparks. The tanks slammed and pounded their massive Tower Shields like mad.

They moved with a single purpose, like the pulse of one enormous heart.

For those who had gone before them, and as they waited for the battle ahead, they looked to their new Alliance Leader.

They waited for his final words.

"Today, we fight until the very last person."

Clang-clang-clang!

“WAAAAH!”

Countless auras surged upward at once, as if on cue. Their distant cry rose as one voice and drove back the darkness.

The candles that had lit the plaza were long since out, but humanity’s flame still burned.

At least until they fell here today.

Until the darkness came to extinguish that final flame.

SHWAAAA…

At that moment, the wind stopped.

The air trembled.

The plaza, heated to a fever pitch, went cold. Countless eyes turned in the same direction.

There stood a being cloaked in darkness.

“Ah…”

A moan escaped someone’s lips and reached my ears.

My senses, floating as if submerged in water, came back to me. The hairs all over my body stood on end.

The Demon King.

Instinctive fear and wariness rose in me. Unlike before, I turned my head of my own will. Following everyone’s gaze, I looked at him.

Demon King Asmodeus.

The accursed king who had driven humanity into the flames in the past—and would do so in a future that had yet to begin.

And the moment I stared into the writhing darkness in the distance—

Crack…

The world around me collapsed. Every illusion shattered.

Chapter 831

I could've sworn I heard something like that.

CRASH.

The sound of a window shattering.

It was the signal that it was time to leave the illusion around me and return to reality. An alarm waking my mind from its deep slumber.

Fwoosh.

The scenery around me melted away like ice cream. The shouts that had sounded so clear now seemed distant, like echoes.

"Chaaaarge!"

The last battle of the Great War. Perhaps the final battle, with humanity's fate hanging in the balance.

Team Leader Choi strode forward, the Hero's Sword held high, and countless Hunters followed him like a surging wave.

Toward somewhere the moonlight couldn't reach.

Toward a being standing alone, cloaked in darkness.

No.

Not yet. Not yet.

I reached out with all my strength. Through my blurring vision, I moved the body that had become entirely my own and took a step toward him.

Demon King Asmodeus.

I could see the back of that calamity. He wasn't enormous or grotesque.

Even if all of this was an illusion that would never come to pass, I wanted to see his true form with my own eyes—the form no one had ever told me about.

I wanted to catch even a glimpse of him buried in the deep darkness, to feel the power coiled within him, if only for a moment.

More. Just a little more!

I didn't know.

Maybe my desperate cry had echoed in my heart and reached him. Or maybe everything I was seeing and feeling wasn't an illusion after all, but something else.

There was only one thing I could be sure of: something had reacted to my soundless cry.

Rustle.

A figure slowly turning around. Darkness rippling.

"…!"

My heart lurched. An icy chill ran down my spine.

It made no sense. It was impossible.

But the Demon King was definitely turning toward me—and that was the last thing I saw.

Flash.

Everything around me disappeared. Team Leader Choi and Xiao Shen, the countless Hunters. Even Demon King Asmodeus.

But the darkness did not disappear.

No—an abyss-like presence was closing in, pressing in on me from every direction.

What the hell is this…

I was confused. I couldn't tell what was happening.

Was what I was seeing another illusion? Or had I finally reached my limit, lost consciousness, and started dreaming?

And just as those questions gripped me—

Ding.

> **System** You are the Chosen One. The Master of the Ark.
> The System automatically activates its firewall.
> The System blocks a newly detected virus.
> Abyssal Swamp has been dispelled.
> Power of the Abyss dissipates.
> Level 10 "The Final Abyss" Doppelganger has been blocked.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Clear chimes reached my ears and rang out in every direction.

At the same time, the darkness that had writhed toward me like a living snake rapidly scattered.

It shuddered violently, as if it had encountered something it feared.

And then I realized what this abyss was.

I knew what had brought all those illusions crashing down on me, too.

Doppelganger.

A line I'd read somewhere suddenly came to mind.

When you look into the abyss, the abyss looks back at you.

The line meant something else, but it described what had happened to me.

I looked at the Doppelganger, and the Doppelganger looked at me. That was how I'd been dragged into the abyss it had created.

No—that was what had happened.

But now I knew.

This was another illusion within reality. The Doppelganger's power itself.

And I knew what I had to do.

Fwoosh.

Heat surged from my empty hands. Darkness writhed against the dazzling blue-white flames.

As if I'd made up my mind to do this long ago, I reached out with hands blazing with Scorching Yang Qi and seized the darkness.

CRUNCH.

And the instant I tore it apart—

SHRAAAK!

I saw it.

The darkness crumbled away, reduced to ash by the flames. Beyond it, the world I remembered came into view.

Huff.

Dusty air flowed through my nose and mouth.

The chunks of stone that had hung in midair began to fall again. The Skeleton King came into view, staring at me with wide eyes.

It all happened in an instant.

Had even a second passed in reality?

But I'd experienced at least several hours—years' worth of illusions—and returned.

There probably wasn't a single survivor among those who'd gone through what I had. They must all have been absorbed by the Doppelganger.

"What the…"

I couldn't explain it in a few words, and there was no time to try.

Instead of answering the confused Skeleton King, I shook my head.

Then I left him behind and faced the Doppelganger, which was staring up at me in a daze.

"You—you… What are you…?"

Rustle.

Its shadowy body wavered and kept scattering, bit by bit.

What I'd torn apart with my flame-wreathed hands wasn't just an illusion. It was the Doppelganger's body, its very life.

"I got a good look at your last-ditch effort."

"…!"

"Yeah. I figured there had to be some reason that dog barking its head off this whole time was cooperating so easily."

At my offhand remark, the Doppelganger shuddered.

Darkness welled up from it like blood, then scattered like ash. Each time, the shadow that served as its body grew smaller.

“Honestly, it wasn’t a bad attempt. If I’d been in my usual shape, you wouldn’t have stood a chance. But I didn’t expect some fucker to cut in without using his turn signal.”

“This can’t… This can’t be happening.”

“If a bastard like you can exist, why can’t a bastard like me?”

The Doppelganger muttered as if groaning.

“The Chosen One…”

The Chosen One. The Master of the Ark.

I didn’t know why the Doppelganger and the System called me that.

I didn’t know who had chosen me, or what the Ark was. I couldn’t know that right now.

But if those two words referring to me weren’t just nonsense, then I knew at least this much: stopping that fucked-up scene the Doppelganger had shown me must be the mission I’d been given.

“Brace yourself. Everything you saw will soon become the future—and reality.”

“Are you sure? I may be a genius, but I’m not exactly planning to die young.”

The Doppelganger laughed out loud at my reply. Its helplessness and madness were impossible to hide now that it had accepted its complete Erasure.

“If the King returns, will you still be able to say that?”

I thought of the deep darkness I’d seen in the illusion.

I thought of that last glimpse of Demon King Asmodeus, whose appearance I’d never managed to make out clearly. I thought of the overwhelming strength I’d felt from him, even from a distance.

If I fought him, could I really win?

An empty question.

I already knew the answer.

Demon King Asmodeus was strong. No—there was no point even talking about how strong he was.

If that had been reality, and the power I’d felt was real, just meeting his gaze would’ve frozen my hands and feet.

But sometimes a question has more than one answer.

Especially when I’m the one solving it.

“If I fought him as I am now, I’d definitely die. Miserably, without even managing to hurt him properly.”

At my answer, the Doppelganger’s laughter grew louder. It didn’t seem to care that more than half its body had already disappeared.

“Yes. That is the truth. Accepting the death our King has decreed is all you can do…”

“You’re leaving out a premise.”

"What?"

I looked at the Doppelganger as it fell silent and continued slowly.

"If it were me right now. That's the most important premise."

At some point, I'd changed. I'd had no choice but to change in order to survive, in order to protect what mattered.

I'd thrown away the caution I'd held on to as an F-rank Hunter. Sometimes I'd faced my enemies boldly—and with even greater recklessness.

And every time I risked my life in a fight, I'd reaped the rewards of that risk.

That's how it's been so far, and that's how it'll keep being.

The man I am now and the man I'll be in the future are different.

So the future has to change, too. Whatever risks I have to take—even if it costs me my life—I'll change it with my own power.

That's all I can do. And it must be why someone I don't know chose me.

"An illusion is just an illusion. We'll have to wait and see how the future changes… but some bastard who's about to drop dead won't be around to find out, so it's none of his business."

The Middle Dantian is moved by mental strength, and mental strength comes from a steadfast heart.

I won't be shaken by some horrible illusion or a few words from the Doppelganger.

"And you seem to have forgotten something important."

I was tired. I felt like I could collapse at any moment.

But as I looked down at the Doppelganger, which had stiffened, I wanted to make sure I said this.

"The future's already changed."

I pulled at the corner of my mouth, stiff with dried blood. Fighting off the sleep that threatened to overwhelm me, I went on.

"I put an end to your plan. With my own hands."

I didn't know exactly what the Doppelganger had planned to do or what it had hoped to achieve.

I'd wanted to hear it directly from the thing itself, but it would be completely gone in a few seconds. There was no point asking now.

I could find everything out.

Even if I had to scour the whole world, I'd track down every trace of the Doppelganger and pull up the roots it had left behind. Then the illusion would remain an illusion.

Peace would settle over the future that had been filled with calamity.

I can do it.

This wasn't just a wish. I was certain.

At last, the world had come together. I'd sounded the alarm for those who'd grown complacent in times of peace and thrown cold water in the faces of the powerful who'd refused to confront reality.

And I'd brought those known as humanity's sword and shield—the countless Hunters—together under one flag.

The World Hunter Federation.

An organization that transcended gender, race, age, and national borders.

I was the Alliance Leader at the head of that vast federation.

Everyone had chosen me. Everyone trusted and followed me. So there was no room in my heart for the word *impossible*.

"So…"

My voice trailed off, growing weak.

My vision slowly tilted against my will. Without a word, the Skeleton King suddenly came up beside me and reached out to support me.

He helped me finish what I hadn't yet managed to say.

"Quit your bullshit and go link arms with your friend who went ahead of you. You can watch from there."

Whoosh.

My toe came down hard, with a heavy rush of air.

And in that moment, something inexplicable caught my eye through my hazy vision.

Was it… smiling?

I couldn't possibly know.

Was the smile an illusion brought on by exhaustion? Or was it a reality I couldn't understand?

Before I could even think back over that fleeting question, the toe, still wreathed in a faint flame, had already stamped down on the shadow. It led a monster that had lived through ages beyond imagining to Erasure.

BOOM!

The shadow shattered and scattered with a deafening crash. Through it rang the clear chime announcing the Doppelganger's Erasure.

Ding.

It was over. At last.

At least in that moment, I was sure it was.

Until an unpleasant noise pierced my ears.

Beep.

> **System** Main Quest Cataclysm has failed!

...What?

Chapter 832

Sometimes, what you've always taken for granted goes wrong.

A moment when something you'd always taken for granted—one is followed by two, and two by three—suddenly takes an unexpected turn.

But I'd never once imagined this outcome.

Beep.

> **System** Main Quest Cataclysm has failed!

...What?

I froze like a statue and stared blankly at the holographic window floating in the air.

Inside its translucent frame were the same words I'd just heard.

Main Quest. Failed.

The two words drilled into my retinas, tearing through the emptiness in my mind and leaving me reeling.

Why? How could this happen?

My lips moved on instinct, but no sound came out.

With endless questions swirling in my mind, I shook my head. The world spun around me. No matter how I looked at it, I couldn't make sense of what was happening.

Was I dreaming?

Or was I still trapped in an illusion the Doppelganger had created?

I wished I were. Unfortunately, this was real.

"...Human, snap out of it!"

A voice reached me through my blurred vision. If the Skeleton King's hand shaking me was proof that this was all real—

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The chimes kept ringing, and the darkness scattering into the air like ash was proof that one being had been erased.

> **System** You have defeated Level 10 "The Final Abyss" Doppelganger.
>
> Due to the extreme level difference, you receive no Reward.
>
> With the death of this target, the Doppelganger species has been completely wiped out.
>
> You have completely eradicated a species. The name Doppelganger will now slowly be forgotten as time passes.

> You have achieved the very rare achievement, Where's Your Do Clan From?[3274]
>
> As a Reward for achieving a very rare achievement, you have gained a massive amount of EXP and Fame!
>
> You have acquired the Title Species Slayer!
>
> Level Up!

Another Level Up. Another recovery.

Fwoosh.

My foggy vision cleared. Strength surged through my revitalized body, more powerful than before.

None of that mattered.

Something else was far more important.

I'd failed the most important Quest—the one I'd been certain I would complete.

The Doppelganger was erased. I'm sure of it.

My body was brimming with strength, but my mental reserves had run dry long ago. The shock made me stagger.

Michael Silbert was dead. The Doppelganger was dead. With my own hands, I'd eliminated the beings that threatened this world.

I'd thought it was over. It should have been over.

Even if a new threat came someday and plunged the whole world into fire, I'd believed we could at least buy ourselves some time right now.

But we hadn't.

That smile.

I couldn't breathe. A terrible headache stabbed through my skull like an awl, and I remembered the Doppelganger's final moments. That faint smile I'd dismissed as a trick of my eyes.

I didn't see it wrong…

I'd been wrong. That smile was real—the smile of someone who had finished what they'd set out to do.

Where had things gone wrong? Had I not tried hard enough? Had I not been strong enough?

Or had the calamity I'd tried to stop been in the making for so long that no mere human could have prevented it?

I didn't know. I couldn't tell what had happened.

I was sure of only one thing: something that should never have happened had begun.

[3274] The Korean title is a dialect-flavored pun that sounds like "Where are you from, Mr. Do?" while also evoking a question about one's ancestral clan.

Boom. Ba-boom.

A drumbeat suddenly reached my ears.

Neither a clear chime nor a mechanical warning, it was more ominous than any sound I'd ever heard. A war drum heralding the start of a great war—and a warning from the System.

Ba-boom.

> **System** Main Quest Cataclysm has failed.
>
> Some details in the Quest window have been updated.
>
> Mission: Stop the Summoning (Failed)
>
> You have failed to complete the mission.
>
> The boundary of the Demon Realm has temporarily opened. Unidentified beings are invading this world.
>
> A page of history is turning, and a new age is right around the corner.
>
> The rift has begun.
>
> Current rift progress: 10%
>
> As the rift progresses, the distribution and concentration of magical power will rise sharply. These changes may vary by location and over time, and may affect the laws and living beings of this world to varying degrees.

"…!"

I stared wide-eyed at the new holographic windows.

The Demon Realm.

A cursed world no one had ever glimpsed, crawling with darkness and monsters. A land of death ruled by Demon King Asmodeus.

It had opened. Only temporarily, but it had opened.

Cursed beings, summoned from another dimension by someone else, had set foot in this world.

A rift. Magical power surging.

So this was the plan the Doppelganger had prepared.

I'd underestimated it.

It had manipulated the whole world from behind Michael Silbert and made itself a divine figure in a vast religion. It was that cunning.

Why had I assumed a creature like that wouldn't have a failsafe for a plan it had spent more than thirty years preparing?

A bomb doesn't care who owns it. Whoever holds the switch, the slightest jolt can set it off.

Just like now.

Dammit.

My mind went blank.

The bomb had already gone off. The rift had begun. A calamity beyond anything Mutated Gates or Monster Waves could compare to would spread like wildfire.

"We have to stop it. Right now."

Grab.

I seized the Skeleton King's wrist. He'd been watching my inexplicable behavior ever since the Doppelganger died, and now he shouted in confusion.

"Get a grip, human! It's already dead."

"No."

"What?"

"This is just the beginning. It's not over."

"What are you talking about—"

"Tell the main force. Tell the World Hunter Federation. Right now."

I struggled for breath. My hand trembled around his wrist.

I was tired. I wanted to rest.

The mental exhaustion that had been eating away at me, combined with the shock I hadn't seen coming, kept dragging me toward darkness. The sleep demon pressed down on my eyelids with the weight of ten thousand geun.[3275]

But—

Crunch.

I bit my tongue and fought off the sleep. Forcing my fading consciousness back, I went on.

"We failed. The Doppelganger's plan worked."

"…!"

"They're coming."

That was all I managed to say.

Slump.

"Human! Human!"

The Skeleton King tried to haul me up with his powerful hands, but my body went limp against my will.

As my consciousness sank after the long fight, I thought of the best thing I could do now.

Murim.

The Main Quest had failed, but regardless of the outcome, the System's restrictions were gone. The wall separating the two worlds had crumbled.

I had to go back.

[3275] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g, or about 1.32 lb. Ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg, or about 13,200 lb.

To the other world that had given me a second life. To the place where time flowed so slowly that I could delay the flames of calamity.

But…

Why was I so sleepy? Why couldn't I think?

Log…

The three syllables I'd always called out so confidently faded inside my mind. Before I could finish that one short word, my thoughts sank beneath the water.

And just as I was about to plunge into complete darkness—

Ding.

A clear chime sounded, followed by a voice that might have been a hallucination.

> **System** The System is automatically executing a new update.
>
> The System wishes to move the Player under its authority. Do you accept this offer?
>
> The Player has not responded. Proceeding automatically.
>
> Connecting to Murim.
>
> Countdown begins.
>
> 10, 9, 8…
>
> .
>
> .
>
> .
>
> Login successful.
>
> May fortune favor you in battle.

Fwoosh.

A burst of light announced the opening of a new world. I let go of the last thread of consciousness I'd held on to.

Ahomed Jemal Pasha.

His name was long by ordinary standards and short for a man from the Middle East. He trembled with joy alongside the dozens of companions gathered around him.

"Ah… Ahhh…"

"Inshallah!"[3276]

It had been an unbearably long time. It was true for Ahomed, whose family had followed God's will for generations, as it was for the others.

[3276] *Inshallah* is Arabic for "if God wills."

Though they'd been blessed with a talent for magic that anyone would envy, they'd had to hide from the world and live like criminals. They'd had to keep secret their great plan to change the world's fate.

But…

We did it. At last.

Ahomed felt hot tears running down his face before he even realized it. He had devoted his entire life to following only the Prophet's words.

In the old mage's eyes lay the relief of someone finally free of all his hardship, the joy of fulfilling God's mission, and worry and sorrow for someone who wasn't there.

O Prophet. Our guiding light. Where are you now?

He had an inkling of what it meant that the Prophet had not returned from confronting the infidels' army. But Ahomed kept his feelings to himself.

If the Prophet had died, it was a holy sacrifice in service of God's mission. A martyrdom. He must not grieve.

Perhaps he foresaw a day like this long ago.

No. A great prophet like him would surely have foreseen it all.

That must have been why, before leaving, he had summoned Ahomed, the one in charge, and impressed these instructions upon him.

> "Ahomed. If I haven't returned by dawn three days from now, you and the others who remain must complete the mission."
>
> "P-Prophet, how could you say such a thing?"
>
> "It's only a precaution. If you all don't stay here to protect everyone and carry on the mission, how can we fight the infidels' army without worry?"
>
> "B-but…"
>
> "I trust you, Ahomed. You are my brother and Disciple, bound to me in the name of God."

Neither the Prophet—no, the Doppelganger—nor Ahomed knew that he would never return. That a single human would erase him forever.

Yet that was exactly what had happened. Sensing that something had gone wrong, Ahomed led the mages who had studied under the Prophet alongside him to the Magic Formation they had spent so long preparing.

And now, in this very moment—

They watched the darkness rise, devouring more Magic Gems than they could count.

"O Messenger of God! O God's hammer, come to set this defiled world right! At last, descend upon us!"

His cry rang out, carrying a lifetime of pent-up anguish and a faith that could only be called fanatical.

Fwooooooosh.

Deep within the darkness, red eyes flashed.

Chapter 833

Dazed.

A weightless sensation, as though gravity had ceased to exist, filled Jin Taekyung's body.

Jin Taekyung opened his eyes amid that alien sensation and stared blankly at the unfamiliar sight spread out before him, beyond a field of vision full of static like a broken television screen.

Where am I?

A look around gave him the answer.

Stalactites hung from the ceiling. The floor was wet, the air damp.

He hadn't recognized it at once because it was impossibly vast, but he was in a cave.

And in that cave, marked here and there by human hands, tens of thousands of people had gathered.

"Ooh. Oooooh…"

"Inshallah!"[3277]

Their cries reached him faintly, like echoes.

Someone in a long robe called out, and people sank to their knees in a wave that passed through the crowd like falling dominoes.

An old man with a hunched back, a man and woman clutching each other's hands, children whose eyes had been shining with innocence—none remained standing.

No. They were all there was: ordinary people of the sort you could see anywhere in the Middle East.

Only one group stood out among them: figures in robes covered with unfamiliar patterns.

Swish.

The hem of a long robe brushed the floor. An old man with snowy hair showing beneath a loosely wrapped turban spread his arms wide.

"O Messenger of God! O God's hammer, come to set this defiled world right!"

At his cry, Jin Taekyung noticed something stranger than anything else in that unfamiliar scene.

That's…

It was darkness. And fire.

Countless Magic Gems were piled almost to the ceiling, enough to fill half the enormous cavern. They fed the flames like kindling.

[3277] *Inshallah* is an Arabic expression meaning "God willing."

Darkness so dense it seemed impossible to have missed until now rippled like fire. An unprecedented power writhed within it, ready to burst forth at any moment.

Fwooooooosh.

Rapture filled the old mage's eyes as he watched. Though his body shook, he raised the staff in his hand and cried out once more. Light poured from it.

"At last, descend upon us!"

At that moment—

Crack.

The space beyond the tightly sealed darkness opened its jaws, like a child forcing its own way out of the womb.

The black flames thrashed like a writhing dragon and swallowed countless Magic Gems. Pure, unrefined magical power coursed along the Magic Formation carved into the ground and flowed into the flames.

On and on. Until the Magic Gems had poured out all their energy and crumbled to ash.

Crackle.

The mountain of Magic Gems began to break apart. It collapsed.

Jin Taekyung watched in shock as those masses of magical power, their purpose served, lost their strength and scattered.

He watched the enormous bomb he'd been searching for with such desperation ignite—the seed of calamity that had slipped away somewhere, hidden from the world's eyes for decades.

And at last, calamity in full bloom stepped through the crack in space.

Step.

A snow-white bare foot touched the ground. Two legs and two arms, no different from a human's. Yet the red gleam in the man's eyes marked him as unlike anyone else.

Haaah.

The black-haired man wore not a thread of clothing. He breathed slowly.

Like a sailor home after a long voyage. Or a predator before a tempting meal.

His eyes, so recently gleaming red, had turned pitch-black. Through them, he took in this new world, seeing and sensing everything around him.

The faint sunlight filtering through the ceiling.

The damp air. The tens of thousands of people pressed flat against the wet floor as though worshiping a god.

And finally, the old mage staggering toward him.

"Ah… Ahhh…"

The mage, Ahomed, stared at the man with tears streaming down his face.

Skin so translucent the veins showed through. A face of unbelievable beauty. And an immense power surging within him.

There could be no doubt.

The man before him was God's messenger, a being who could truly be called a divine man.

"O Prophet, are you watching? At last, your prophecy has come true—!"

The instant Ahomed opened his arms toward the man—

Slice.

His trembling voice cut off. The old mage's body collapsed like a rotten log.

Thump. Thud.

His arms and legs, torn apart. His upper and lower body, severed.

And last of all, his head slid diagonally off his torso and hit the ground.

It rolled like a ball of thread until it reached the man's feet. He looked down at the dead mage's face.

"You did well."

That was all.

The darkness writhing around the man drew in the corpse, now cut into dozens of pieces. It swallowed, broke down, melted, and digested them.

Crunch.

The horrible sound of bone and flesh being crushed rang through the silent cavern.

"…!"

The tens of thousands who had seen it happen froze.

So did the mages who had been celebrating their success moments ago. And so did the one man watching it all through a dreamlike haze.

That's him.

Jin Taekyung knew it instinctively.

The strange man standing alone before them was something that should not exist in this world.

A demon who had crossed through that slowly closing crack in space from a world of death cursed by God.

Rustle.

The darkness, having devoured the corpse without leaving a drop of blood, coiled around the man from head to toe. It became fine black silk, clothing him, then settled across his shoulders as a cloak.

No. At the same time, it rose behind him like enormous wings.

Flash!

Jin Taekyung saw it.

The darkness spread without end. It blotted out the sunlight leaking through the ceiling and cast death over the heads of people frozen like statues.

The living and the dead.

A storm of magical power that swallowed them all.

The cavern shattered. Terrible screams rose. The nightmare surrounding Jin Taekyung broke apart, and he woke.

CRUUUUNCH!

Hah.

I opened my eyes and let out the breath I'd been holding.

An unfamiliar ceiling came into view. Somewhere, hooves clopped, and my body rocked gently to their rhythm.

"Ah."

I blinked with a low groan. One deep breath steadied me, drawing hot, humid air into my lungs.

This is…

I didn't need to look around to know.

I was lying in a carriage. I recognized Nanman's heat and humidity, though I hadn't felt them in a couple of months.

Of course, given the difference in how time passed between here and the modern world, it had probably been only a few shichen,[3278] not two months.

That last System notification wasn't a dream.

Relief hit me so suddenly that all the strength went out of me.

In my final moments in the modern world, my mental strength had been drained so completely I couldn't even attempt Login.

If the System hadn't helped, even by force, I would've stayed collapsed for days without knowing what was happening… No, wait.

System update?

Those words stood out amid my jumbled memories.

If all the System notifications I'd heard were true, then something had changed—something that had never happened before.

I sat up in a hurry and gave the command in my mind.

Open Status Window.

Nothing happened, just as I'd half feared.

However hard I stared at the empty air, no translucent window appeared. Nor did I hear the clear chime that should have accompanied the command.

[3278] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

"…Shit."

The curse slipped out before I could stop it. I was rattled, but I had a fair idea why the System had suddenly stopped working.

System update.

Maybe I can't use it until the update's done?

I'd always preferred using my body to sitting at a computer, even as a kid. But anyone with a smartphone knew what an update was.

What threw me was that I'd never imagined the System would have one.

I guess it's a program too. It makes sense that it could update.

What kind of lunatic made a thing like this, let alone updated it? Still, it had happened.

Then again, maybe an update was nothing special. The System already connected two worlds and let me level up like I was in a game.

Besides…

After what happened.

I remembered the unbelievable things the System had told me right after I erased the Doppelganger.

And I understood all over again that the vast, terrible calamity I'd failed to stop had begun.

Clench.

My hand tightened without me realizing it. My fist had gone white and trembled. At the same time, the scene from the nightmare flashed before my eyes.

The truth was, I still didn't know what I'd seen.

Had the System secretly shown me something real through a dream? Had my confused subconscious made it all up?

Or was it some kind of prophetic dream?

I wanted it to have been nothing more than a nightmare. Instinct told me otherwise.

That wasn't… just a nightmare.

I'd seen it clearly, even through the static. I remembered.

The crack in space opened, if only briefly, using countless Magic Gems and a Magic Formation as its medium. And the man wreathed in a monstrous amount of magical power, slaughtering tens of thousands of fanatics who could offer no resistance.

No—the demon who, for some reason, looked human.

No way.

A name came to mind. I forced it away.

I still didn't know what he was. But judging by the Doppelganger's attitude when we spoke and the way events had unfolded, that man wasn't Asmodeus.

Even if—if he really was a Demon King…

I have enough time.

I could shut myself away and train as I had on Mount Jiuhua. A little over a year could pass for me in Murim while only a few days went by in the modern world.

As long as the System existed, time was on my side.

Dark Heaven might not be, though.

I got up and looked around the carriage.

Was sleeping in carriages the latest fad at the Nanman Beast Palace? Even allowing for exaggeration, the interior was about as roomy as the private wing of a large inn. And I was alone.

Quiet is nice, but where did everyone go?

None of the familiar faces who should have been nearby were there.

The people from the Fire Dragon Pavilion. Hyuk Mujin, who should've been sitting beside me as my guard and nodding off. And Jeok Cheongang, whose jaw had dropped when I told him about the modern world and he mistook it for the realm of immortals.

Where the hell did they… Hm?

I was wandering around the carriage to loosen up when a familiar voice reached my ears.

"The Earth Mother Goddess has already scrapped the Central Plains. So who does the Central Plains martial world revolve around now? Our Captain. That's right, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Ooh. Oooooh."

What the hell was he talking about?

I listened past the surrounding murmur to the voice carrying over it.

"And who is it that believes in and follows that Blazing Flame Divine Dragon? It's me. Want to know why? Because I've got my place at the Captain's side locked down! I'm his most trusted subordinate—that's why my place is secure."

"A firm grip? How so?"

"Captain, don't move! Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, mess with me and you're dead! That's how close I am to our Captain. Incredibly close."

"Ohhh."

"Who's the Earth Mother Goddess's son? The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon! And who's got a tight hold on the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon?"

Just as his speech reached its climax, I stuck my head out the window.

"Listening to all that has me curious. Who is it?"

Hyuk Mujin laughed heartily and turned.

Then his eyes met mine, and he went stiff.

"Me! Hyuk Mu—uh, fuck."

“Fuck?”
“Ah.”
“Ah?”
Come here, you bastard.

Chapter 834

Everyone has their own way of forgetting their troubles.

Some people soothe their grief with books and music. Others shake off their anger with good food and a drink.

Getting physical works, too. Run until you're gasping for breath, exercise hard enough, and all those half-baked thoughts get wiped clean from your mind.

I'd always preferred that last method. I was born weighing over eleven pounds, after all—a record-breaking baby at the local maternity clinic.

"Nothing beats vigorous exercise. Don't you think so too, Mujin?"

At my voice, soft as a cat's paw, Hyuk Mujin—who'd been listening to my lecture on "overcoming your troubles"—finally opened his tightly shut mouth.

"No."

"No?"

"Yes."

"Why not?"

"Because you're going to hit me."

"Who says? I haven't even said anything yet."

"Your fist, Captain. It's practically howling."

Hyuk Mujin's eyes trembled as he looked at me—or, more precisely, at my clenched fist. I nodded readily.

"Yeah. You're right."

"…You're admitting it that easily?"

"I have to. That's reality."

"Could you spare me just this once?"

"People could misunderstand that question. Anyone listening might think I'm trying to kill you."

"You may not kill me, but you hit me like you're trying to."

"When did I do that?"

Hyuk Mujin stared at me in disbelief, then shouted as if his life depended on it.

"Yesterday! The day before! Since last year! All the time! Rain or snow—"

Wham!

"Urgh!"

There's always a reason someone gets beaten up.

I got into the swing of it, happily beating Hyuk Mujin until my troubles in the modern world began to fade. Then I sensed people approaching, and familiar voices came through the slats of the tightly shut carriage window.

“Why did the carriage stop—wait, why are there only guides here? Where’s Hyuk Mujin?”

“I don’t see Taishan either!”

After the urgent voices of a young man and woman came an old man’s shout.

“What! That Taishan brat has disappeared?”

“Yes. He should be with Hyuk Mujin and the other guides, protecting the Pavilion Master.”

“Oh, thank you, gods of heaven and earth. Ever since I met that bastard, the back of my head’s been throbbing, and I thought I’d kick the bucket any day now. Looks like I’ve got another twenty years in me.”

“Now that’s going too far!”

“Going too far, my ass. What’s going too far is the appetite of that underling of yours—Taishan, Scenic Mountain, whatever his name is. I’ve spent decades in Nanman and seen all kinds of strange beasts, but I never imagined there’d be a man who ate more than an elephant.”

“Now, listen here, Elder Nam!”

“Hey, hang on. This little shit’s been mouthing off at me for a while now… You think you can act like this in front of Senior Jeok? You’re still wet behind the ears—how dare you raise your voice at an elder!”

As that dizzying conversation went on, Hyuk Mujin, sprawled on the floor and twitching, called out.

“I-I’m right here! Help me!”

A short silence followed. Then everyone shouted at once.

“Dark Heaven! It’s an attack by Dark Heaven!”

“Hyuk Mujin will be fine—save the Pavilion Master first!”

“Damn it, were the guides in on it too? Then Taishan must’ve—!”

“By this old man’s keen eye, that Taishan brat’s in on it too! If he shows up, kill him! Please, kill him!”

Clang, clang, clang!

As swords were drawn and the Nanman guides screamed in terror, I found myself thinking:

Ah. I miss Mom.

Murim really wasn’t easy.

The people who saw me step out of the carriage unharmed reacted in all sorts of ways.

“We’re saved!”

“O Apostle of the Earth Mother Goddess!”

“Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell!”

The guides from the Nanman Beast Palace, who’d been branded Dark Heaven’s lackeys and nearly killed without a chance to explain themselves, sank to the ground.

“Huh?”

“Huh?”

Soul-Chasing Guest Song Ilseom and Black Dragon Saber Sama Pyo had been ready to cut someone down first and ask questions later. They both froze at the same instant, like mirror images.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung… was with Dark Heaven all along?”

Namho, a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent who’d lived in Nanman for decades since the Great Faction War, finally started showing signs of dementia.

“Benefactor!”

Last of all, Ju Hwaran—the Escort King’s granddaughter and the Young Bureau Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau—ran toward me with a cry that sounded almost like a scream.

She threw her arms around me.

Well, coming to Murim really had been the right call.

But I was a man who kept personal feelings separate from official business, no matter the circumstances. I forced the corners of my mouth to stay down and spoke solemnly.

“What shampoo do you use?”

“I was so worried something had happened to you, I was terrif—what?”

“N-Nothing.”

I must have been a little out of it.

I took a deep breath to collect myself. Ju Hwaran asked, her voice full of concern, “Are you really all right?”

“I’m fine all year round—rain, snow, thunder, hail. But seriously, what shampoo do you use?”

“Oh no. You must have hit your head.”

“…Sorry. I didn’t hit my head. I’m just a little confused.”

That stream-of-consciousness thing is no joke.

I’d only just returned from the modern world, and maybe I was still half asleep. With my tongue doing whatever it wanted, proving I was in my right mind took a little time and effort.

Which meant submitting to a test administered by a certain old, eccentric Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent.

“What is this old man’s name?”

“Why do I have to do this?”

“Answer the question. I’ll ask again. My name?”

“This is driving me nuts.”

“This old man’s name isn’t Mi.”[3279]

“Wow, I’m going to lose my mind.”

“It isn’t Wa, either.”

I was about to say I was going crazy, but gave up and answered.

“Namho.”

“Then what’s my affiliation?”

“Hidden Shadow Pavilion.”

“Wrong.”

“What?”

“This old man isn’t just a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent. I’m its finest agent.”

“Aren’t you just its oldest agent?”

“…”

Namho glared at me without a word. Hyuk Mujin, who’d finally escaped the Truthful Carriage and was recovering, muttered,

“His memory and judgment seem fine to me.”

“Bah! What do you know, you fool!”

“Whoa. Why are you getting so mad?”

“This old man has a plan, too. What would you do if the fellow in front of you were a Dark Heaven lackey wearing Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung’s face?”

“I suspect infirmities of old age, but no, he isn’t. I’ll stake my neck on it.”

“What’s your evidence?”

“I got hit before everyone came over. That punch felt exactly like the Captain’s.”

“…”

“His fist sticks to my skin like glue. My body remembers it. My soul remembers it. I only get that feeling when the Captain hits me.”

Hyuk Mujin looked at me with a sad smile.

“I’m glad you woke up, Captain. I was really worried these past three days.”

I’d been wondering if I ought to hit him a little less from now on. At that, my brow furrowed.

“What did you just say?”

“Huh? What about?”

“Did you say three days?”

“Oh. You didn’t know? You woke up briefly three days ago, then slept the whole time after that, groaning and sweating.”

[3279] Namho pretends to hear the opening sounds of Taekyung’s exasperated Korean remarks as surnames.

"…Of course I didn't know. How would someone who was asleep know?"

Hyuk Mujin rubbed the bump on his head, looking sheepish.

"Sorry. Anyway, everyone was in an uproar over it. Elder Nam searched everywhere nearby with the others, saying they had to find medicinal herbs. Great Hero Jeok left right away, saying he was heading to Sichuan."

"Old Master—no, my Master went to Sichuan?"

"Yes. I've never seen him in such a hurry."

"But why Sichuan… Oh."

Before I could finish the question, a thought crossed my mind.

The Sichuan Tang Clan.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had dealt the Sichuan Tang Clan a devastating blow a few months ago. But the strength of a great family didn't disappear overnight.

Besides, the Sichuan Tang Clan, which mainly dealt in hidden weapons and poison, was also one of the most renowned medical families in the world.

And on top of that…

The Divine Physician is in Sichuan.

Strictly speaking, the Divine Physician known to the world was actually the Slaughter Saint. But unlike his master, the Disciple had stayed in Sichuan, and he was a physician every bit as worthy of the title.

Jeok Cheongang had gone ahead to bring that new Divine Physician back.

He didn't have to go that far.

I felt a pang of regret that I wouldn't get to see him right away, and a warmth stirred in one corner of my heart. Then a stabbing pain rose from deep inside my body.

This is…

There was no doubt. Separate from the System update, the effects of Broken Body remained.

That damage, which even leveling up hadn't healed, was needling me around the lower dantian.

Mm.

I swallowed the groan, but I couldn't stop my brow from furrowing a little. The people watching me noticed at once.

"C-Captain. Is something wrong?"

"No. I've just got something on my mind."

That wasn't a lie.

I was thinking about my injuries—and about Jeok Cheongang, who'd noticed them three days ago.

Old Master must have gone to find the Divine Physician because he realized he couldn't treat me himself.

I could say this without a doubt: Fire King Jeok Cheongang was a great martial artist and a good Master.

But my injury, which even the System couldn't heal, must have seemed beyond Jeok Cheongang, too.

Fuck. At first I thought I'd borrowed from a regular bank. Turns out it was a Sunshine Loan.[3280]

I felt like a gambler who'd borrowed from loan sharks to keep playing, only to ruin his life.

But what choice did I have now?

Even if I could go back to that moment, I knew I'd make the same choice. All I could do was give a bitter smile.

It couldn't be helped.

The stakes in those gambles hadn't been gold bars or checks. They'd been my life—and someone else's.

If I hadn't used One Annihilation at each of those moments of crisis, I wouldn't still be alive.

It bought me breathing room. I guess it's time to pay the debt.

The System wasn't someone I could sit down with and talk to, and I had no intention of whining at it. It had already given me more than enough and warned me again and again.

Every path I'd walked until now had been my own choice.

That's enough. It is what it is.

With that, I cleared the jumble of thoughts from my mind.

Thinking about it alone wouldn't make anything better right now. I had to consider how the people around me felt, too.

I'm really a considerate person, aren't I? No, wait a second.

"Then where'd that Taishan bastard go?"

"Huh?"

"Huh?"

Everyone blinked at my sudden question. One of the guides from the Nanman Beast Palace edged over.

"Um… the big fellow went to get something."

Namho looked baffled. "Went to get something?"

"Yes."

"What on earth?"

[3280] Sunshine Loan is a South Korean government-backed loan program for people with limited access to conventional bank credit.

"Well, um…"

The guide was about to answer when—

Rustle, rustle, rustle!

The bushes some fifty jang[3281] away shook, and a huge figure burst out. He was so massive you had to wonder if he was human.

"Taishan! Brought it!"

He raised the dark object in his hand high.

"Taishan's favorite thing in the world—no, a miracle cure for the sick Pavilion Master!"

The people watching stared blankly and murmured.

"That's honey."

"Right. A pot of honey."

"Sorry to interrupt, but isn't that a beehive, not a pot of honey?"

"That's true, too."

Bzzzzzzzz!

It was the first time I'd ever seen it.

Bees that big—and thousands of them all swarming together.

"…Primordial Heavenly Venerable. Gods of heaven and earth."

Leaving Namho's sorrowful voice behind, we all quietly climbed back into the carriage.

Murim really wasn't easy.

[3281] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Fifty jang is about 152 m (497 ft).

Chapter 835

Splaaash.

Sudal sat at the bow of the ship as it cut swiftly through the current, lost in thought. He was a river pirate of the Yangtze River Channel League and Deputy Stronghold Lord of the Water Dragon Stronghold, which held sway over Hubei Province.

Looking back, things have gone pretty well so far.

Sudal had made quite a name for himself in his line of work.

He was deputy lord of a major stronghold with more than five hundred river pirates under its command. And though it had taken him a long time, he had finally reached the Peak level of martial arts.

Simply staying active and in one piece as he approached fifty made him a model of a successful river pirate. But Sudal had achieved more than that.

I've saved up a decent amount of money, too.

Few water strongholds had hundreds of fighters.

On top of that, Mu Song, the Ship-Fire Boy who headed the Water Dragon Stronghold, was a shrewd man with powerful backing: he was a direct Disciple of the Alliance Leader of the Yangtze River Channel League. As his deputy, Sudal had made plenty just by picking up the scraps that fell his way.

Of course, a good deal of that wealth had gone to pleasure houses.

Could I buy a decent manor somewhere out in Hubei? Property prices have probably gone up again, though. Fuck. Do they plate the pillars in gold or something?

Sudal stared gloomily at the current, which broke into rough waves around the ship.

I never thought I'd be thinking about stuff like this.

Retirement? Settling down?

A few years ago—not even a few months ago—those soft, mushy words wouldn't have crossed his mind.

Sudal had always prided himself on being a born sailor and river pirate.

But not anymore. His carefree life as a raider, and his life as a bold man of the water, were both slowly coming to an end.

Even at this very moment.

"Um, Deputy Stronghold Lord?"

At the cautious call from behind him, Sudal squeezed his eyes shut.

I'm fucked.

It wasn't a guess. He was certain.

Ever since they'd left the wretched land of Yunnan five days ago, the same nightmare had come around again and again.

I thought we might make it through the whole day for once…

The inevitable had arrived.

But Sudal didn't run. He resolved to face it like a brave river pirate and answered.

"I'm listening. Speak."

"Well, you see, it's just…"

"Talk, or get your ass kicked."

"I'm too old to want a beating, so I'll talk. It's just… do we have any beef?"

Sudal turned slowly toward the familiar face of his subordinate.

"Are you that eager to get your ass kicked?"

"Of course not."

"Then say it again. What meat?"

"I need beef. Specifically, beef marinated in a spicy sauce."

"Beef. Spicy marinade…"

Sudal trailed off and took a deep breath. Recent experience was teaching him to recover the composure he'd forgotten decades ago.

"You know where we are right now, don't you?"

His subordinate nodded enthusiastically.

"Of course. We're aboard the swift ship, the pride of the Water Dragon Stronghold, symbol of the mighty Yangtze River Channel League!"

"And where is that swift ship?"

"We've finally left that godforsaken Yunnan behind and are crossing the Yangtze on our way to Sichuan."

"Then one last question. In the middle of the Yangtze, when it's been well over a month since we set foot on land, can we get our hands on marinated beef?"

"No."

"Correct. You're smarter than you look."

"Thanks, I guess."

The subordinate smiled awkwardly at the rare praise, then suddenly turned serious.

"But we have to bring some back."

"I said we don't have any."

"He said to make some if we don't."

"Could it be… that bastard?"

His subordinate looked around before answering in a voice kept low with great effort.

"Sure enough, it's that bastard."

You could always count on him to be the one.

Neither of them said the name, but they both knew.

At the moment, there was only one lunatic who'd demand spicy marinated beef aboard a ship crossing the Yangtze.

Taishan, the Tiger Giant Child.

Spending thirty years as a river pirate meant seeing all kinds of idiots and morons. But even a seasoned pirate like Sudal had never seen anyone like him.

A build and appetite that barely seemed human. Simple-mindedness that could shock even the most uncultured river pirates.

Actually, Sudal had once met another lunatic of much the same sort, albeit one considerably smaller.

"Shit. I'd almost forgotten him, and now I'm thinking about that bastard too."

"Who're you talking about?"

"That guy."

"Oh. That guy."

They both thought of him at the same time.

The young man who looked perfectly normal but seemed possessed by some kind of ghost, stuffing his face with dumplings and sweets whenever he got the chance.

Sudal gazed wistfully back on those days a few months ago, then let out a sigh.

Before Hubei was stained with blood, he'd been living a peaceful, sensible life as a river pirate.

"Still, things were a lot better when he was around. At least he brought his own food."

"What the hell are you talking about? He'd gobble it all up, then raise hell demanding candied hawthorn skewers.[3282]"

"Oh, really? That's what happened?"

"I'm telling you. The second he made eye contact with you, he'd start whining for those skewers. That *horo* bastard was something else."[3283]

One lunatic demanded beef with the sauce already on it, and another demanded candied hawthorn skewers.[3284]

Sudal shuddered at their cruelty. But then, as now, there was nothing he could do.

The lunatic who wanted beef was a Peak master from the Black Dragon Demon Gate, one of the foremost factions among the unorthodox. He was also the right-hand man of its Young Sect Leader, who was all but certain to inherit the sect. And that little shit he'd mentioned was a far, far bigger figure than even him.

If it's Cheongpung, the Huashan Divine Dragon, he's a big shot among big shots.

[3282] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional Chinese street snack made by coating hawthorn fruit with hardened sugar.

[3283] The Korean name for the snack, *bingdanghoro*, lets the speaker repeat *horo*, an insult meaning "bastard."

[3284] Candied hawthorn skewers are a traditional Chinese street snack made by coating hawthorn fruit with hardened sugar.

His backing was insane: the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, was his Master, and the Sect Leader of Huashan was his Senior Brother.

In terms of seniority alone, he stood on equal footing with the Sect Leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang. And according to popular opinion, his talent for martial arts ranked among the top three of all time.

The heavens are cruel. Why give all that to a bastard like him?

As Sudal looked up at the clear sky and lamented his fate—

Crack!

Something broke, followed by a shout like the roar of a beast.

“Beef! Taishan wants beef! Spicy marinade!”

Sudal’s subordinate turned pale.

“This is bad. He’s already at moderate rage.”

“Moderate rage?”

“I’ve watched him for the past five days and worked out the stages. Once he reaches full-blown rage, he’s barely human.”

“Pretty sure he’s been like that from the start…”

“Anyway, give him something, anything! Right now, before he puts a few holes in the swift ship!”

“What?!”

Sudal snapped out of it and told him where he’d hidden his emergency supply of drinking snacks.

“There’s a jar in the corner of my cabin.”

“Beef?”

“No. Salted pork. Top quality.”

“That still won’t be enough, will it?”

“Of course not. With his appetite, I wouldn’t be surprised if he ate the jar too. But what if you went with the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate?”

“Ah!”

“Go. The fate of this ship is in your hands.”

“That’s our Deputy Stronghold Lord!”

The subordinate gave him a thumbs-up and hurried off. Sudal watched him go with a proud smile and rubbed the bridge of his nose.

“That boy…”

But the smile vanished.

Instead of taking their possessions, he was giving them a ride—and he still had to worry about this.

He’d even felt proud of himself for coming up with a decent solution. The misery suddenly welled up in him, and his eyes grew wet.

Is this why I became a river pirate?

A sudden sense of futility weighed on him, but Sudal forced himself to shake his head.

No. He only had to hang on a little longer.

It had already been five days since they left Yunnan. With heaven's help and a good wind, they might arrive within a day.

Then he could say goodbye to those wretched people…

"Hey, don't block the way. Move over."

"Huh?"

Sudal blinked, shaken from his thoughts. An old man who looked stern as hell stood before him, holding a fishing rod.

"You…"

"You?"

"No, Elder…"

"Elder?"

"…What should I call you, then?"

"Just call me Senior. And get that hideous face of yours away from the bow. The Dragon King would turn tail if he came up for some fresh air and saw your mug."

"Ah, yes. Understood, Senior."

The old man hadn't been with them when they sailed from Sichuan toward Yunnan about two months ago.

Now, five days into their voyage back, Sudal still didn't know exactly who he was. But looking at him, the old man somehow gave off the air of a master.

Especially…

That forehead.

The old man's forehead was black as if it had been painted, and swollen to twice the size of anyone else's. Sudal couldn't take his eyes off it.

I've heard of external arts like that.

Sudal quickly moved away from the bow and studied him before speaking cautiously.

If he could get on the good side of a mysterious old master who'd been living in seclusion in Nanman and obtain the formula for a martial art, what better fortuitous encounter could there be?

"Um, so…"

"Don't talk to me. I'm concentrating."

"Yes, sir."

Silence fell at once.

Just as Sudal was watching for a chance to speak, the old man sitting at the bow with his fishing line cast suddenly shouted.

“Enough! You brat!”

“Me?”

“Do you know what kind of person I hate most in this world?”

“W-what kind?”

“A man who never finishes what he’s saying!”

“But, Senior, you’re the one who—”

“Shut that crafty mouth of yours and finish what you were going to say. I’m going out of my mind wondering.”

Sudal stared at the old man, who already looked like he was out of his mind.

I thought I’d finally escaped the Fire King, and now there’s another crazy old man!

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, had already left for Sichuan ahead of them on another swift ship.

Sudal had foolishly thought he could breathe easy again. Swallowing his misery, he spoke.

“I was wondering if you’d learned Iron Head Technique.”

“Iron Head Technique?”

“Yes. As far as this junior knows, masters who’ve trained Iron Head Technique to its limits have black foreheads and can even break steel…”

“Hm. I don’t know where you heard that, but you know your stuff. That’s right. Iron Head Technique has different levels and forms, but once you reach Great Completion, you can easily block even Sword Energy.”

“Ooh! Then could you be the famous Great Hero Ironblood Elder?”

The old man scoffed.

“Great Hero? What nonsense. That Ironblood Elder is the lowest of the low. One of the scum of the Murim who absolutely must be hunted down and killed. Though he might already be dead. He spent the entire Great Faction War pretending to sit on the sidelines, while he was up to all kinds of dirty business behind the scenes.”

“Oh. So you aren’t Great Hero Ironblood Elder. I mean, that scum.”

“Obviously not. Are you picking a fight with this old man?”

“Absolutely not. Then, if you don’t mind, who are you?”

“Me?”

The old man puffed out his chest.

“My name is Namho.”

“Ah! Namho?”

“That’s right. I’m *the* Namho.”

Namho smiled fondly as he thought back on his youth. Sudal wondered.

Who the hell is Namho?

Perhaps he was an old master from the previous generation. Sudal couldn't recall ever hearing the name.

Then the old man spoke again, and Sudal, who'd been unsure, couldn't help but jump in shock.

"I killed dozens of fiends during the Great Faction War."

"Dozens!"

"That's not all. A thousand orthodox martial artists owe their lives to me, and twice that many members of the Demonic Cult died because of me."

"Wow! A thousand, then another two thousand! A hero born of the Great Faction War!"

"The Nine Sects and One Gang? The Five Great Families? They're strong, very strong. But charging in and swinging a blade isn't the only thing that matters. What matters is victory in battle!"

"Wow! Victory!"

"When I was young, whenever I sent out a messenger pigeon, the great sects everyone had heard of would move, huh? And sometimes the Three Saints and Ten Kings would rush right out!"

"Wow! The Three Saints! The Ten Kings! You must be the Martial God at the very least!"

"And that man was me, Namho!"

"Wooo! Long live! Long live! Long live our Senior!"

Sudal threw both arms up and shouted along. Then something struck him as odd, and he blinked.

"Um, what did you say just now?"

"What are you talking about?"

"Er, I thought I heard you say you sent out a messenger pigeon."

"Yeah. I did. From the rear."

"…?"

"Is that a problem?"

Sudal stared at Namho, who remained completely unashamed. After a brief silence, he parted his lips.

"Then, Senior, do you have a title?"

"No."

"Your martial arts…?"

"Why would I learn something like that?"

"…?"

"Being a martial artist is dangerous as hell, and hard work. When you're young, you show off and get stabbed to death. When you're old, your body's a wreck."

"…!"

“Look at you. You’re trembling right now. You’re getting old, your martial arts are mediocre, and your body’s starting to give out. Might be a stroke, so if you’re interested, come along. I’m on my way to see a famous physician.”

About half of what Namho said was true.

Sudal had already lost it. But he wasn’t trembling from a stroke—he was trembling with rage.

He held on to his last thread of reason long enough to ask one final question.

“T-then what about that Iron Head Technique you mentioned?”

“I said I knew about it. I never said I’d learned it.”

“But if you haven’t even learned Iron Head Technique, why is your forehead so—”

“I got stung by a bee.”

“…!”

“Some beastly bastard disturbed a Black Gold Bee hive because he wanted the honey, and I nearly died for it. We somehow managed to draw out the venom, but this swelling just won’t go down.”

Namho gently rubbed his black, swollen forehead. Sudal felt dizzy, as though he’d been stung by a bee himself.

What kind of fucked-up situation is this…?

Two months.

A whole two months. He’d left merchant ships laden with wealth and grain behind and, under what was practically a threat, been dragged from his home base in Hubei to Sichuan, then all the way to Yunnan.

And it still wasn’t over.

The waiting had gone on forever. He’d stopped in Guangxi for a chance to make some pocket money, only to be caught by the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang—who was known as the Blood Monk—and dragged along.

It was easy to call it two months, but being trapped on a ship with the ugliest, most uneducated people in the world had made those two months feel like two years.

All I have to do is take them to Sichuan, then I can go back to Hubei. And this is how things are going right to the end.

One beast of a man spent all day shoving whatever he could into his mouth. Now Sudal had been fooled by a powerless old man he’d never met before and insulted for his trouble.

That wasn’t all. The rest of them were just as crazy.

Hyuk Mujin—whom he’d met enough times to recognize—was going around preaching some religion called the Earth Mother Goddess to his subordinates. Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo, who’d looked like they disliked each other from the start, had dueled on deck and half destroyed the mast.

And Ju Hwaran, one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes and the most beautiful woman in Sichuan?

Two months ago, when they'd set out for Nanman, she'd looked like a fairy. Now she spent her days coming out onto the deck to watch everyone.

And whenever she heard even the slightest sound somewhere, she'd prick up her ears and mutter as though she wanted everyone to hear.

Oh. The Pavilion Master still needs to rest. Does that barrel really have to be moved right now?

Oh. That rope scraping is so loud. Should I just cut every rope so the Pavilion Master can be comfortable?

Oh. Why's he gulping down water like that? Couldn't he go without drinking and slowly dry up instead?

Oh. The waves are so rough. What if the Pavilion Master suffers qi deviation while circulating his qi because of all the noise? You're river pirates, aren't you? Can't you do something about a single wave?

What was he, the Dragon King? How was he supposed to calm a raging river?

He'd put up with enough. For five days, he'd seen everything he never wanted to see and heard everything he never wanted to hear.

That's it. I've got nowhere left to retreat. I'm settling this today.

Overcome with fury, Sudal drew the broad-bladed saber tucked into his waistband.

Or, he tried to.

Until a familiar voice sounded behind him.

"Whew. I feel so much better after getting a good rest. Hey, mister, how far have we come?"

Sudal turned slowly. Jin Taekyung had shown himself for the first time in five whole days. Sudal raised his eyes to him and answered with a grin.

"Hehe. We'll be there soon."

That night, the swift ship arrived in Sichuan, and Sudal decided to retire.

Chapter 836

Five days. Short, depending on how you looked at it. Long, depending on how you looked at it.

I couldn't say which it felt closer to.

But one thing was certain: it was enough time for the swift ship the Yangtze River Channel League was so proud of to travel from Yunnan to Sichuan along a tributary of the Yangtze.

It's been a while since I was here.

I murmured to myself and looked at the scene spread out before me.

A stretch of the Yangtze so vast it looked like the sea. As the sun went down, the river had turned black, its surface streaked with lights of every color.

"Those are…"

Namho narrowed his eyes. Hyuk Mujin supplied the answer to what those countless distant lights were.

"Pleasure boats."

"Do you think I asked because I didn't know?"

"Oh, you know about those too, Old Man Nam? I thought you'd never seen one, since there's nothing like that in Nanman."

"Hah!"

Namho snorted so hard I wondered if he'd done it through his ass instead of his nose. Then he gave a hollow laugh.

"Have you ever seen such a fool? You've already forgotten what kind of man this old man is."

He was right. Namho wasn't just an ordinary old man from Nanman.

Nanman blood ran through his veins, but he knew the Central Plains' geography and customs better than plenty of old martial-world veterans who'd chewed their share of bok choy[3285] in their youth.

It might all be in the distant past now, but Namho had once been one of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's finest agents.

"Oh, right. You're around so much, I keep forgetting."

Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head sheepishly. Namho nodded at him with a solemn expression.

"I'll forgive you. It's only natural—you find this old man so sociable and approachable."

"You are approachable. You remind me of Grandpa Hong, who lived next door when I was a kid."

[3285] Bok choy is a Chinese leafy cabbage.

"Grandpa Hong? I don't know the man, but if he reminded you of me, he must have been a good person."

"He made a fortune lending money at exorbitant interest. He always took bodyguards with him when he went to the market, probably because he'd given so many people reason to hate him. Anyway, he ended up dead."

"…"

"But if you knew what pleasure boats were, why were you staring at them like that?"

Is this bastard trying to start something with me?

Namho glared at Hyuk Mujin with exactly that look, then let out a deep sigh.

"I wasn't staring because I found them fascinating. It left me feeling hollow."

"Hollow?"

"Yes. It made me think how little the Central Plains have changed."

Namho gazed at the ships gliding along the Yangtze, their lights bright in the distance, and continued slowly.

"Some people risk their lives fighting to set a collapsing world back on its feet. Others float pleasure boats and lose themselves in indulgence. How could I not find it absurd? How could I not feel hollow?"

"Ah."

"I'm not blaming you, young as you are. Nor am I telling you to be angry with them. But there's just one thing I'd like to ask of you."

Hyuk Mujin had fallen silent. Namho looked at him and the others one by one, then added bitterly, "Whatever you see, please don't lose heart. As long as you have the will, you can get back up no matter how many times you fall. But once your will breaks, you can accomplish nothing."

This wasn't the Namho we usually saw.

This was advice from a veteran who'd weathered the storm of the Great Faction War—and from an old man.

And I wasn't imagining the way his gaze lingered on me in particular.

He's worried. Right now, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung is just a kid who's never been through a proper war.

I was young even by modern standards. In Murim, people had all the more reason to worry about me.

I'd only started making a name for myself in Murim less than two years ago. And on top of that, I'd barely passed twenty.

To an old martial-world veteran, Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan was far too young to be expected to have matured mentally.

Of course…

Hunter Jin Taekyung is different.

If someone asked whether I'd grown up, I'd probably say no. I still acted like a kid now and then—or pretty often, honestly—and let my emotions get the better of me.

But at least I wasn't so easily shaken that the people around me needed to worry.

No. I'd been through too much for that.

Someone I'd believed was on my side—someone I'd once even looked up to—had stabbed me in the back. I'd lost someone close to me in the process.

While I risked my life trying to save people, the media tore into me, and people online split into two camps and waged another war.

Even when a country's capital falls and a hundred thousand people are killed or injured, there are bystanders everywhere.

People who click on the news without a hint of feeling, then close the article before they've read half of it.

Why?

It's obvious.

They've got a new game to play, or it's time to head to the club.

Or they're the sort who don't care if tens of thousands die, as long as it happens on the other side of the world instead of next door.

Once, every one of those things hurt.

But as time passed, my heart—scratched raw by countless strangers whose faces I'd never seen—grew calloused and hard. The pain that used to pierce deep into me eventually became familiar.

Yeah. That was enough.

I had too much on my shoulders to let every little thing wound me and make me suffer.

"They're having a good time."

I finished thinking, gave a quiet laugh, and said it aloud. Namho's eyes widened at my words. Then he, too, gave a bitter smile.

"Yes. They are."

I didn't know whether that had reassured him. But given time, he'd see for himself.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung wasn't just some kid overflowing with strength and talent.

"Let's go. The moment we reach the landing, we move out. No dawdling."

At my order, Taishan shot his hand up.

"Taishan wants five-spice pork."

"Five-spice pork?"

"Yes. Taishan's favorite."

"Five-spice pork sounds good. It's delicious."

“Captain. Good. Taishan and Captain agree.”

“But are you sure? By the time we get to an inn, you’ll have swallowed so much river water there won’t be room in your stomach for five-spice pork.”

Taishan looked back and forth between the river, black enough to hide its depth, and me, fully prepared to administer the Yangtze dip-and-taste punishment. He slowly lowered his hand.

“No. Taishan thought again. Taishan doesn’t want five-spice pork.”

“You sure?”

“Mm-hm. Sure…”

His voice drooped. Sama Pyo gave him a sympathetic look. Namho, looking disappointed for an entirely different reason, beckoned to the head of the river pirates.

“Hey, Sea Otter. Come here.”

“It’s Sudal.”

“That’s what I said. Sea Otter.”

“Sudal…”

“Sea Otter.”

“…”

Messing with a man’s name like that.

Watching the river pirate’s face as Namho stubbornly mangled his name until he didn’t even have the energy to argue, I felt sorry for him.

I patted his shoulder sympathetically.

“Come on, we’re almost there. Hang in there a little longer.”

“Th-thank you, Great Hero Jin.”

“I know we’ve been pretty hard on you. When we see Senior Mu Song, I’ll tell him Uncle Heimdall had a rough time.”

“Sorry, but who’s Heimdall…?”

“Your name isn’t important right now. Let’s get to the landing first. Mister, are you sad to see us go? If you are, we could spend a week cruising around the Yangtze together.”

Sudal’s—or Sea Otter’s, or Heimdall’s—unfocused eyes flashed. Whether it was anger or madness, I couldn’t tell. He bellowed at his subordinates until his voice nearly gave out.

“You lazy bastards! Pick up the speed!”

“…”

Judging by his reaction, they really must have had a rough time.

Then again, with the Fire Dragon Pavilion members being impossible to control, it was no wonder.

Even Ju Hwaran, the only woman in our party and the only sane one, was showing signs of something wrong.

"Ah, does he have to shout so loudly? The Captain's already exhausted. What if all that noise gives him qi deviation? What's he thinking?"

"…"

At this point, even hearing it scared me.

Her lips kept moving as she muttered, but she had the diction of a Murim Alliance announcer and the projection of an opera singer. Every word hammered into my ears like a nail.

I'd only been out of the cabin for half a day, and I was already feeling it. The river pirates had endured five whole days. Their faces had gone pale.

They look more likely to suffer qi deviation than I do…

As I seriously considered their condition, their leader hurried over. He'd been directing the swift ship, burning through the last of his energy.

"G-Great Hero Jin. There's a problem."

His face, already as terrifying as a demon's, had gone stiff.

Good thing we were on the Yangtze. If this were the Grand Line,[3286] that face alone would've sent his bounty soaring and made him a government target.

I asked with sincere concern, "I knew this would happen. Have your qi and blood gotten tangled up?"

"What? No. I'm perfectly fine—"

"I'll do whatever I can. Don't hold it in—tell me what's going on. Your complexion's awfully dark. And you're looking off in a completely different direction. You're a wreck."

"My face has looked like this since I was born. And my eyes have been like this ever since my father beat me when I was fifteen."

"Pardon?"

"Please don't misunderstand. He was just startled. He'd been sleeping soundly, then woke up suddenly and saw my face the moment he opened his eyes. I probably would've thrown a punch too."

"Ah. Your father…"

An ordinary person might have been flustered. They'd stammer, struggle for something to say, then offer an apology worse than saying nothing at all.

But with the composure of a Supreme Peak master, I pointed naturally at the fireworks lighting up the sky.

"Whoa, look. Fireworks. Is there a festival?"

"They're fireworks, but it isn't a festival. That's the problem."

"A problem? What's wrong with setting off a few fireworks?"

[3286] An allusion to *One Piece*, a Japanese pirate manga in which the government posts bounties.

“Look closely. At the ships, not the sky.”

The ships? What about them?

I lowered my eyes without thinking.

The pleasure boats had come much closer. At last, I understood why Sudal had hurried over.

“Those are…”

“They’re not all pleasure boats. No wonder there were so many more lights than usual.”

He was right.

From a distance, those ships had seemed like just a few more lights among the rest. Up close, they looked ten times bigger and sturdier than any pleasure boat I knew.

More like…

“Huh. They look like military vessels.”

“They are military vessels.”

“Oh.”

That stopped me for a moment, but it didn’t really matter.

Military vessels, my ass. What was there to worry about?

The Yangtze River Channel League’s flag was flying from the swift ship I was on, and I knew perfectly well that this huge band of river pirates had long ago greased the officials’ palms and made friends in the right places.

Or at least, I thought I knew.

Bang. Bang. Baaang!

Fireworks burst one after another. The military vessels turned at an angle, presenting their broadsides. Something dark appeared between the sturdy wooden planks.

“Sea Otter, what’s that?”

“Looks like a cannon.”

“I know that. Are you messing with me, Heimdall? Why are they aiming it at us?”

The river pirate leader, by now stripped of his name entirely, gave a hollow laugh.

“Because the fireworks they just set off were the signal to attack.”

“What?”

The moment I asked again, dumbfounded—

BOOOOM!

About a hundred cannon barrels belched fire at once.

Chapter 837

Boom! Boom! Boom!

White smoke billowed up with the flames.

The iron balls hurtled across more than two hundred ja[3287], smashed the swift ship, and crushed everyone aboard into minced fish…

Naturally, none of that happened.

The only thing this world could do far better than the modern twenty-first century was martial arts—not science.

Boom! Splash!

The iron balls struck the water instead of the swift ship, sending waves surging upward.

Taishan snatched a fish out of the air as the blast sent it flying toward the deck. He looked dejected.

“Taishan sad. This not five-spice pork.”

“…”

Since when did five-spice pork come from the Yangtze?

I gave Taishan a frosty look, then tapped the back of the Water Dragon Stronghold’s Deputy Stronghold Lord’s head. Like the other river pirates, he was crouched on the deck like a shrimp.

“Get up. You’re a river pirate. Why are you so scared?”

“Gasp! Am I alive?”

“Did you think we’d all died?”

“But I saw them fire with my own eyes…”

“They fired, all right. Their aim was terrible.”

Even people who pissed at least once or twice a day sometimes missed the target. Was firing an old-fashioned cannon supposed to be easy?

Only about half of the hundred or so iron balls had been fired properly, and more than half of those hadn’t come anywhere near us.

The ones that had miraculously reached the swift ship had merely served as sacrifices to the river’s wave pool.

Well, I suppose they’ve only fired a few shots now and then during training.

It made sense when I thought about it.

The age when warlords rose like wildfires and fought for supremacy had ended long ago.

[3287] A *ja* is a Korean unit of length equal to about 30.3 cm (11.9 in). Two hundred ja is about 60.6 m (199 ft).

Even modern humanity, after going through the Great Cataclysm, had settled into peace in just over thirty years. *Hunter* had come to mean a profession, not a calling. Of course the soldiers of this unified dynasty, ruled by the Son of Heaven, had grown lax.

There was just one thing I didn't understand: why were they suddenly firing cannons at us?

"I'll ask them."

"Pardon?"

"I was talking to myself. Don't worry about it. Just steer the ship."

"Pardon?"

"Get moving. Do you want to spend the night here?"

"Pardon?"

If failing to understand something this simple counted as a talent, he had it in spades.

I clicked my tongue at the Deputy Stronghold Lord, who just kept staring blankly and asking me to repeat myself, then called over a nearby river pirate.

"Hey, you there."

"M-me?"

"Yeah. You're the acting captain now, so steer the ship. Oh, and hang a white flag where they can see it, just in case."

I didn't know what had happened in Sichuan while we'd been in Nanman, but I had no intention of attacking government troops just because a few cannonballs had landed nearby.

The government and Murim might have an agreement not to interfere with each other, but martial artists were still subjects of this land. We could end up charged with something as serious as treason.

Did some local river pirates cause trouble recently?

As I thought it over, the swift ship—which had paused for a moment—started toward the landing. One of the river pirates shouted.

"They're reloading!"

Not great news, but not something I was particularly worried about, either.

Even if I didn't step in, we had human shields who could easily stop a few old-fashioned cannonballs.

"Earn your keep."

The moment I tossed out that one line—

Boom!

The second volley thundered, and a faint whistle came from behind me.

Whoosh!

Sama Pyo, Taishan, Song Ilseom—and finally, Ju Hwaran.

In the blink of an eye, they raced across the deck. The brilliant light they unleashed met the iron balls hurtling toward the swift ship.

Slice! Crash!

Thump. Thump. Thump.

Boom! Boom! Boom!

Drums beat an urgent rhythm beneath the unceasing roar of cannons.

On the largest and most splendid of the dozens of pleasure boats, a young man watched a singing courtesan dance and gave a quiet laugh.

“I don’t know what kind of scum they are, but their luck is rotten.”

His voice was thick with drink, his eyes relaxed. The others had been watching him warily, knowing his usual temperament, but now they finally laughed along.

“Ha ha. That’s what happens to the uneducated.”

“If they knew Young Master was here, they’d abandon their boat and run a thousand li[3288].”

“But… that flag concerns me.”

The young man turned to the speaker.

“The flag? What about it?”

“Have you heard of the Yangtze River Channel League?”

“The Yangtze River Channel League…”

Cup in hand, the young man searched his memory for a moment. Then it came to him.

“Oh, those river pirates? Of course. There was a group called the Yangtze River Channel League where I stayed before.”

“Yes, exactly. They’re notorious scoundrels, even in the martial world. And the boat our navy is attacking is flying their flag.”

“And?”

“The government and Murim aren’t supposed to interfere with each other. Besides, the leader of the Yangtze River Channel League is known for his vicious, devious nature. I worry this might cause trouble…”

His voice, so assured a moment ago, gradually trailed off.

The pleasure boat fell quiet. The smile on the young man’s lips faded.

Clack.

He set his cup down roughly, splashing the wine inside.

“Trouble?”

[3288] In this Chinese setting, a *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi). A thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

Every one of the people around him wore lustrous silk and had the bearing of wealth and status.

Some looked young enough to be his peers; others were old enough to be his father. All held their breath and watched his every move.

“I’m genuinely curious… What sort of trouble are you worried about?”

“Th-that is…”

The merchant who’d spoken first stammered.

He ran a sizable trading company in Sichuan, and he already regretted opening his mouth.

He’d even paid a bribe to attend this gathering, hoping to win the young man’s favor. As a merchant, he’d heard and seen a lot, so he’d spoken without giving it much thought. Now, instead of catching the young man’s eye, he was about to fall out of favor.

“I-I’m sorry, Young Master.”

The apology came too late to calm the young man’s temper.

His eyes, drooping drunkenly a moment ago, had risen into their usual cunning slant.

How dare a lowly merchant…

The young man glared at the back of the merchant’s bowed head.

He valued authority and dignity above all else. Yet this man had stood before him and spouted nonsense about being worried by some martial-world ruffians.

The Yangtze River Channel League?

A grand name, but in the end, it was just a collection of stinking, uneducated river pirates.

No matter how inviolable the boundary between the government and Murim was, to the young man they were nothing but bandits who ought to be beaten down on sight.

What had happened a few months ago had only hardened that belief.

“Those martial-world ruffians are merely subjects of the Great Nation. What is there for any of you to worry about?”

At the chill in his voice, the others hurriedly bowed their heads.

“Y-you are absolutely right!”

“I have no concerns at all. The government troops are as sharp as blades, and with a Young Master as wise as you here, why would we fear a few martial artists?”

The cannons had long since drowned out the music. The courtesans’ garments, which had fluttered like butterflies, had fallen still along with the mood.

The young man stood alone, looking down arrogantly at the bowed figures.

Pathetic. What are a few martial artists, anyway?

The drunken haze that had felt pleasant just fifteen minutes ago now irritated him. Even the courtesans, who'd seemed to have descended from heaven, had lost their appeal.

Perhaps it was the terrible memories from not so long ago. His anger refused to subside. He raised a hand and pointed toward the Yangtze.

"Everyone, raise your heads and look at those river pirates! Watch them shatter before the might of the Great Nation!"

He turned as he shouted—and blinked.

"Huh?"

Did I drink too much?

That was his first thought.

But even after rubbing his eyes hard with his sleeve and looking again, the scene before him remained unchanged.

No, something had changed.

The boat that should have sunk long ago was closing in at tremendous speed.

"Huh?"

"Oh?"

"What the hell is that?"

The courtesans, who'd been watching their employer for cues, and those who'd reluctantly raised their heads at the young man's order, all blinked as they watched the unbelievable sight.

How is it still in one piece?

Didn't they fire the cannons?

They did, though.

Come to think of it, they've been firing this whole time, haven't they?

Huh? They're firing right now, too.

As someone had noticed, more than ten military vessels were still busy firing cannonballs. Their volleys were far more frantic and disordered than before.

"Y-you idiots! Shoot straight!"

"We are shooting straight!"

"Then why aren't you hitting it?"

"We are! We definitely hit it! We heard the sound!"

"Then why is it still in one piece?"

"How the fuck should we know?"

The soldier meant every word of that curse.

They'd fired, and fired, and fired again. By now, the military vessels had launched hundreds of cannonballs between them.

They hadn’t trained enough, and their aim might have been complete shit, but surely one shot should have hit by now. That was just common sense.

And yet… the boat was still in one piece.

The sleek vessel cutting through the black current as it approached from the darkness looked like a ghost.

Why?

Fear crept up alongside the question in every mind.

Every sailor had heard stories of ghost ships that cannonballs couldn’t sink—and whose dead crews wouldn’t stay dead.

I-is it really a ghost ship?

But this is the Yangtze, not the sea.

Then is the Yangtze a sea?

While the soldiers’ absurd thoughts chased one another around, the young man had come right up to the bow of the pleasure boat. He was putting to the test the strange gift he’d received just that day: an instrument called a thousand-li lens.

What he saw horrified him.

“This is insane…”

He muttered the vulgar words without realizing it, then stood there gaping.

Through the thousand-li lens, he could see something he could hardly believe.

Boom! Boom! Craaash!

Cannonballs bounced away amid the thunderous blasts.

No—people were knocking away the cannonballs as they came hurtling toward the ship.

“Y-Young Master. What’s happening?”

At the voice by his ear, the young man hesitated.

How could he explain what he’d seen? Would they think he was mad?

But his concern vanished almost at once.

Through the thousand-li lens, he’d spotted a face he could never forget, however hard he tried.

“Uh, uh, uhhhh!”

Making strange noises as though he’d forgotten how to speak, Ju Wongong shouted toward the military vessels.

“Cease fire! Stop! This is an imperial command—no, an imperial-family command from me, His Majesty the Emperor’s eighth-degree relative!”

Far away, Jin Taekyung recognized Ju Wongong and muttered when he heard the shout.

“I’ve heard of an imperial command, but what the hell is an imperial-family command?”

Namho, who knew a thing or two, answered.

“Imperial-family command, my ass. He’s talking shit. You know him?”
“Yeah. Well…”
Jin Taekyung scratched the back of his head and added:
“I saved his life once when our paths crossed.”

Chapter 838

As you go through life, you meet all sorts of people.

Only a tiny fraction of them become what you'd call meaningful connections.

Most pass through your life by chance, then gradually fade from your memory. Their names. Their faces.

But there are exceptions.

Like the guy sprinting toward me just as I set foot on the landing.

"Young Master Jin! Young Master Jin!"

Was this guy a chance encounter, or a connection that would stick?

I pushed the thought aside and faced the young man, who'd already rushed right up to me.

He was handsome in a refined, aristocratic sort of way, though his upturned eyes made him look sly.

Actually, now that I thought about it, his personality had been a bit like that too.

Right now, though, he looked like a dog reunited with an owner it thought it had lost.

But…

"What was your name again?"

The young man had been panting away as if to prove just how poor his stamina was. At my mutter, he stared at me in shock.

"Y-you mean you don't even remember my name?"

Of course I didn't. Who remembers every extra's name when they watch a movie?

I answered shamelessly anyway.

"Of course I remember."

"Liar! I heard exactly what you just said!"

"You misheard. I talk about you all the time. Don't I, Mujin?"

Unlike the Fire Dragon Pavilion's fresh-faced newbies, Hyuk Mujin was a veteran. Apart from the year he'd spent at Mount Jiuhua, he'd been by my side the whole time.

He caught the signal in my words and answered with a relaxed smile.

"Of course. You've praised Young Master Protagonist so often I've got calluses on my ears."

"See? You heard him, Young Master Protagonist."

I'd shown him some goodwill and found out his name. A perfect bit of banter had me feeling rather pleased with myself—until the young man looked back and forth between Hyuk Mujin and me with a completely flat expression.

"Ju Wongong."

"…?"

"…?"

"Not Protagonist. Ju Wongong."

"…!"

"…!"

After a brief silence, I spoke carefully.

"Did you happen to change your name…?"

"Would I have?"

"Right, no. I just thought…"

"How could you forget? Even now, when I close my eyes, I can still feel the warmth I felt in that cold, dark Dongting Lake!"

At Ju Wongong's deeply wounded cry, everyone around us turned to look at me. I could hear their hushed voices, too.

"What's going on…?"

"Could it be…?"

"No way…"

"Remember that time our captain went from the Night King to a blushing innocent, then turned into a Supreme Peak-level homosexual…?"

I'd wondered which bastard was spouting nonsense like a webnovel title. Turns out it was the very bastard I knew.

I sentenced Hyuk Mujin to death with a glare, then spoke as calmly as I could, keeping a close eye on Ju Hwaran. She'd clapped a hand over her mouth.

"I'll explain everything. It's all a misunderstanding."

And right then—

"Remember that time our captain went from the Night King to a blushing innocent, then became a Supreme Peak-level homosexual? The allegations he denied…?"

For the first time in a while, I lost my temper.

"Hyah!"

The coachman cracked his whip, and the splendid carriage drawn by six fine horses raced down the smooth highway.

A carriage was a symbol of wealth—a luxury anyone with enough money could afford, regardless of status. But a six-horse carriage was different.

Especially when a golden flag fluttered above it.

Clip-clop, clip-clop, clip-clop!

"Clear the road!"

"Make way for Young Master Ju Wongong!"

Dozens of mounted soldiers escorted the enormous carriage, and the golden flag marked it as belonging to the imperial family. The road parted before us like the Red Sea.

"Mom, what's that?"

"Shh!"

Commoners along the road, young and old, hurriedly dropped to the ground. Even the fat, powerful official who'd been lording it over everyone from a sedan chair carried by four men climbed down with a wobble.

Huh. So what I heard before we left was true?

I peered out through the lattice window, then looked at Ju Wongong.

I hadn't seen him in over four months by Murim's reckoning. He looked even more full of life than before.

Well, of course he did. The last time I saw him, he'd looked more like a drowned corpse than a person.

"Everything is thanks to Young Master Jin."

Apparently his face wasn't the only thing that had changed. Had he learned to read minds? Ju Wongong spoke out of nowhere, stroking his neatly trimmed beard.

"After I nearly died at Dongting Lake, I resolved to be reborn. I repented of my old ways, when I did nothing but drink, chase women, and gamble…"

"And yet you were out having a great time on a pleasure boat."

Ju Wongong faltered, then changed his tune.

"I repented, but resolved to cut back gradually. I've also been training my body…"

"You were about to collapse after running just over thirty jang[3289] just now."

"Physical training isn't easy, so I'm taking it one step at a time. Trying to look at the world with an open mind…"

"So you've thought about it, but haven't actually done anything."

My neat summary could've made even Daechi-dong's top cram-school instructor weep.[3290] Ju Wongong fell silent for a moment, then spoke.

"Why are you doing this to me?"

"And why did you do that to me?"

"I only said what came to mind. I never imagined it would cause such a ridiculous misunderstanding."

"You should've known. Before you hurt my feelings."

[3289] A jang is ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty jang is about 91 m (100 yd).

[3290] Daechi-dong, in Seoul, is known for its elite private academies and cram schools.

After spending half an hour explaining the whole “That Time Our Captain Denied Going from the Night King to a Blushing Innocent and Becoming a Supreme Peak-Level Lover of Men” business, I gazed mournfully off to one side and continued.

“One of my subordinates got hurt because of you.”

Ju Wongong followed my gaze and shuddered.

In one corner of the carriage, still racing along without pause, a bloody mess—no, Hyuk Mujin—was sprawled against the luxurious interior.

“But it’s not my fault he ended up like that.”

“You did it. He died because of you.”

“Is he really dead…?”

“He’s alive. For now. But he almost died.”

“B-but that’s because you beat him like you were going to kill him!”

“I don’t remember. When I opened my eyes, he was already like that.”

“Of course you don’t! You’d already gone wild by then!”

“Are you shouting at me right now? Just because you’re part of the imperial family, you think you can go around scaring innocent people?”

“N-no, that’s not what I—”

“That’s it. I’m really hurt. Get out of the carriage. I’m going straight back to my hometown.”

“Why are you telling me to get out of my own carriage? And if you mean your hometown, that’s Shanxi Province. Why would you suddenly go there…?”

“To visit the little—no, His Highness, Prince Shangshan. He must’ve grown quite a bit by now. When I saw him about two years ago, I was even changing his poopy diapers.”

“P-Prince Shangshan! Poopy diapers!”

Even among Celestial Dragons, there were different levels.

Ju Wongong had been horrified at the name of Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao—the Son of Heaven’s only younger brother, the sole Prince, and the chairman of my personal fan club. Then he suddenly furrowed his brow.

“Wait. From what I’ve heard, His Highness Prince Shangshan was already over ten years old a few years ago, and only met you around then. Why would he be wearing diapers?”

Oh, right.

But when a sharp reader catches a sloppy continuity error, there’s no need to panic. I widened my eyes and shot back:

“Are you making fun of His Highness Prince Shangshan for wearing diapers at his age?”

“Huh?”

“This is treason.”

"Wha—?"

"This is treason! Rebellion!"

"You're insane! Shut your mouth!"

"Listen, everyone! Protagonist, a member of the imperial family, has insulted His Highness Prince Shangshan!"

"It's Ju Wongong, not Protagonist! And would you please stop!"

Of course, no matter how loudly I shouted, nobody outside could hear me. I'd sealed off every sound from inside the carriage with my internal energy.

Ju Wongong didn't know that, though. He immediately dropped to his knees.

"I'm begging you! I'll do anything you ask, Young Master Jin, so please stop!"

"I'll have His Highness Prince Shangshan, who brings shame on the imperial family, struck from the imperial genealogy—oh, seriously?"

"I-I mean it. So please, stop. Just let me live."

If you didn't know the situation, you might wonder why he was groveling like this. But the current Son of Heaven had a long and colorful history of purging his own relatives on his way to the throne.

Put simply, he wasn't just an expert at killing his own blood relatives. He was practically the equal of the Primordial Heavenly Venerable.

And if even a hint of the word *rebellion* reached the Son of Heaven's ears?

Rather than waste time on a long-winded excuse, you'd be better off heading straight for the Sichuan Tang Clan. At least the people there knew dozens of poisons that would kill you less painfully than the poisoned draught sure to arrive soon.

"Why are you crying now? Anyone would think you were actually plotting treason."

I patted Ju Wongong on the shoulder. I felt a little sorry for him, but there was a simple reason I was pushing him this far.

It's easier when you've got someone in your pocket.

Before the carriage left, I'd heard why this guy—who should've been stuck in Hubei Province for taking bribes—had suddenly turned up in Sichuan, merrily sailing a pleasure boat.

"My crime hasn't been completely wiped away. His merciful Majesty merely moved my place of exile to Sichuan for a while, and I'm obeying his command. But if some rumor about treason starts going around… Really, really…"

"Yeah, yeah. I understand. But is what you said earlier true?"

I gazed fondly at Ju Wongong, who was still streaming tears, and continued.

"W-what do you mean?"

I gazed fondly at Ju Wongong, who was still streaming tears, and continued.

"That you're the acting City Lord of Sichuan Province."

Ju Wongong sniffled and nodded.

"That's right. I didn't expect it either, but there's no doubt it was an imperial command."

A lot had happened while I was away from Sichuan.

The City Lord of Sichuan Province had suddenly fallen ill. And the other officials weren't trustworthy enough to be entrusted with such a vast stretch of land and its military forces.

That was probably why Ju Wongong had been chosen.

He was a distant imperial relative with no real claim to the throne. He lacked the nerve, ability, and backing to make such a claim, and his only real talent was drinking, chasing women, and gambling. There couldn't have been a more suitable person to fill the empty seat for a while.

But Ju Wongong could offer me more than I'd expected.

His appointment might only be temporary, but his personal incompetence didn't diminish the authority of the City Lord of Sichuan Province.

At least while I'm in Sichuan, I can make sure they're thoroughly prepared for Dark Heaven.

The government and Murim had long maintained an uneasy coexistence.

But if I could mobilize the government's manpower—which dwarfed Murim's—maybe we could uncover whatever Dark Heaven might be planning in Sichuan.

Of course, before that…

"Hey, let's go to the Sichuan Tang Clan."

I had someone to meet. Someone I'd been separated from for a while.

Chapter 839

Time changes many things.

The living. The dead.

Before the laws of time, all things were equal.

Even an absolute ruler who once commanded the world will one day return to the earth. A seed scattered by the wind and mixed into the soil may, hundreds of years later, become part of a dense thicket of grass.

Murim was no different.

In the distant past, people trained in martial arts and built fences around themselves, each pursuing their own goals.

Countless days and nights passed. Great wars and shining heroes came and went, until at last the present arrived.

The Nine Sects and One Gang.

And the Five Great Families.

Fifteen pillars supporting the Murim of the Central Plains.

Deep-rooted trees that had swayed but never been uprooted in hundreds of years.

The Sichuan Tang Clan was one of them.

“Once we cross that hill up ahead, we’ll be there.”

At the coachman’s words, Ju Wongong nodded, then sneaked a look at me.

“It’s a shame we have to part here. If it were up to me, I’d treat Young Master Jin with the utmost hospitality, but…”

“Then let’s go to the city. I don’t mind being treated.”

“Young Master Jin seems to have a great many important affairs to attend to, so we’ll save that pleasure for another time.”

I’d only said it to tease him, but the guy had gone and gotten scared.

I let out a short laugh as I watched Ju Wongong hastily change his tune.

When you got right down to it, he wasn’t exactly a bad guy. He was just incompetent, fond of pocketing money from anyone and everyone, and used his imperial status to live in luxury.

“…”

Now that I put it that way, he did sound like a bad guy. Some of the bribes Ju Wongong had accepted must have come from squeezing the people dry.

He still hasn’t learned his lesson, even after nearly dying. Should I lay into him some more?

The thought must have shown on my face. Ju Wongong went pale and urged the coachman on.

“Every second counts! Pick up the pace!”

"It's not that urgent. Don't hassle a man who's already doing his job. Worry about yourself."

"Every second does not count! Maintain this speed!"

Controlling an avatar like this was surprisingly fun.

Maybe it was even more fun because he was a distant imperial relative and the acting City Lord of Sichuan Province.

Well, I had saved his life, and he was easy to handle. Keeping up a connection with him could come in handy.

"No need to go any farther. Let's stop here. We're almost there anyway, and neither side will be happy if we show up at the Sichuan Tang Clan like this."

We might not have many, but if we rolled up with dozens of heavily armed cavalrymen and a six-horse carriage bearing the imperial flag, we weren't exactly going to draw a welcoming crowd.

The relationship between the government and Murim was, to put it nicely, one of noninterference. In practice, they tended to keep their distance from each other.

"Oh, that's a very good idea."

Brightening at the thought of parting ways with me, Ju Wongong quickly ordered the procession to stop. Then he kindly climbed out of the carriage and opened the door for me himself.

"I hope you'll forgive me for not seeing you off any farther. And I sincerely wish Young Master Jin a future filled with w-w…"

"Martial fortune?"

"Ah, yes. I sincerely wish you the best of martial fortune."

I had no idea how sincere he was, but kind words deserved kind words in return. I smiled and patted Ju Wongong on the shoulder.

"Right. You take care of yourself until we meet again, Your Highness. And maybe cut back a little on the wine, women, and gambling while you're at it. Got it?"

"I understand. I won't forget your advice, Young Master Jin."

"Good. See you."

"Travel safely."

I nodded and shut the carriage door.

Clack.

Ju Wongong, who'd been staring blankly at me through the lattice window, opened the door again.

"Um… aren't you getting out?"

I blinked and asked him back.

"Why would I get out?"

"Huh?"

"Oh, I haven't told you yet. I'm going to borrow this carriage."

"…?"

"As you know, we've got someone elderly and someone sick in our party. I figured a carriage would make things easier. People will clear the way for us on the streets, too."

"…!"

"You Fire Dragon Pavilion folks. Come on in. You've had a hard time riding all this way."

An ordinary martial artist would've been flustered by what I said.

It's an imperial carriage, can we really do this? No, it's all right, I'm fine. One model answer after another.

But the great Fire Dragon Pavilion members were a different breed.

Actually, whatever fresh-faced promise they'd once had had come back from Nanman dyed yellow.

"Aw, shit. My whole body's aching bad enough to kill me, and these Central Plains bastards are so high and mighty they don't even respect the elderly…"

Namho started, muttering as if he wanted to be heard and patting his waist. The Fire Dragon Pavilion members climbed down from their horses and filed into the carriage.

Of course, they didn't forget to make their own comments.

"They didn't even give us five-spice pork. Taishan angry. Want to smash everything."

"Now, now, Taishan. No matter how poorly they treat us, you mustn't do that."

"It reminds me of when I'd just started life as a wandering martial artist. People didn't treat me like a person back then, either."

"Nice carriage, Pavilion Master. Could we take it back to our Escort Bureau later?"

I told Ju Hwaran she could, then turned to the carriage's owner, who stood there stunned, and politely asked:

"Could you pull off the flag hanging there? We're not imperial family, and it'd be a pain if we went around with that thing still on."

"…"

Ju Wongong looked from us, packed snugly inside the carriage, to the cavalrymen staring awkwardly off at the distant mountains. He let out a deep sigh.

Then he yanked the splendid golden flag free.

"Oh, and close the door for us."

"…"

"Don't want to?"

Clack.

Controlling an avatar like this really was a lot of fun.

The first to greet us when we reached the Sichuan Tang Clan were the gruff voice and wary eyes of a gate guard stationed atop the newly built stone wall.

“Stop! State your affiliation and name. If you’re a martial artist, give your title and reason for coming.”

The gate guard’s wariness vanished without a trace the moment I leaned my head out of the carriage.

“Open the gate! Open the gate!”

“Why? Who’s here?”

“I said open it, you little bastard!”

When I first visited the Sichuan Tang Clan a few months ago, I was pretty sure hidden weapons had come flying at me. This time, the gate opened before I could even open my mouth.

Rrrrumble.

As the massive iron gate swung open, the gate guard smacked the clueless new recruit on the back of the head. He clasped his hands in salute to me several times, then rushed off somewhere in a panic.

“Everyone, come outside! The Fire Dragon Pavilion has arrived!”

“What?! Are we under attack again?”

“What kind of crazy talk is that? The Fire Dragon Pavilion led by Great Hero Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, is here!”

“What?!”

Maybe he’d been taking a nap after his shift. A martial artist of the Sichuan Tang Clan, a white trail of drool still at the corner of his mouth, tossed aside the hidden weapon in his hand and came running.

Or, to be precise, it wasn’t just the Sichuan Tang Clan.

“Great Hero Jin! Do you remember me?”

“It’s a pleasure to see you again. Thanks to you, the Disciples of our sect were spared heavy losses.”

“Amitabha.[3291] To think that Benefactor Jin has returned to Sichuan Murim. On behalf of Emei, I offer you my thanks once more.”

“Well, well, who do we have here! Gae-ttong, go get the others!”

The martial artists of the Sichuan Tang Clan, dressed in green uniforms, were joined by Daoists from the Qingcheng Sect, nuns from the Emei Sect, and finally even the beggars of the Beggars’ Sect.

At the sight of that enormous crowd surging in like a sea of people, Namho gaped.

“Hell, what in the world have you been doing?”

[3291] Amitabha is the Buddha of Infinite Light; his name is invoked in East Asian Buddhist practice.

"I more or less told you what happened in Sichuan."

"Even so, this is… It's strange enough that people from other sects are here with the Sichuan Tang Clan, who are famous for their foul tempers. But why are they all coming out like this?"

"I just did a few things here and there."

Namho knew some of what had happened, but I didn't go into detail.

There was nothing more embarrassing than praising myself, and he'd find out naturally anyway.

Still, it looks like everyone's been doing well.

I kept bowing my head as cheers and clasped-hand greetings poured in from every direction. Something tickled at a corner of my heart.

To be honest, I'd been a little worried.

It hadn't even been half a year since the forces of Dark Heaven, led by the Western Heaven Demon Lord, swept across Sichuan.

The Sichuan Tang Clan had been the main target and suffered enormous losses. Qingcheng, Emei, and the Beggars' Sect had all paid in blood, too.

But contrary to my fears, the faces surrounding me now held nothing but joy.

Thank goodness. Thank goodness.

The Outer Court, where dark-red bloodstains had still been visible just before we left, was now full of green grass.

The sky, once blanketed in black smoke from the fires that cremated countless bodies day after day, was clear without a single cloud. Beneath it stood rows of pavilions rebuilt through everyone's help and hard work.

I didn't know whether they had completely moved on from the grief of that day.

But one thing was certain.

The Sichuan Tang Clan—or rather, Sichuan Murim—had risen again.

They had stopped the invisible rift that had persisted all this time, coming together to rise above their grief.

To avenge what they had lost.

And to make sure they never lost something precious again.

Yeah. That's all that matters.

I told myself that firmly, as though making a promise, and climbed down from the carriage.

The crowd had already blocked the road, but more than that, I'd spotted a familiar face approaching in the distance.

Step. Step.

A body so slender it was almost emaciated. A pallid face like that of someone suffering from an illness, and footsteps landing with vigor, as if he were scolding his own frailty.

Step.

Suddenly, he stopped.

The cheers gradually died down, and the crowd parted to either side.

At the end of the path, an old man looked at me with eyes gleaming a soft green.

“It’s been a long time.”

His greeting was not merely stiff—it was cold.

But the next moment, everyone holding their breath as they watched saw it clearly.

The old man, who seemed as if he would never bow to anyone, bent at the waist toward me.

And they heard warmth in his voice—warmth no one there had ever heard from him before.

“I, Tang Sadok, Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan and the Myriad-Poison Asura, have the honor of meeting my family’s Benefactor.”

The unexpected courtesy left me at a loss for words. Tang Sadok clasped his hands in a sincere salute, then looked at me and smiled.

At the corners of his mouth, always sharp and hard as a dagger, dimples appeared—dimples I’d never seen before.

“It’s good to see you again, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

At that one line, filled with the old man’s joy, the suppressed cheers rang out thunderously.

At the same time, another voice slipped through the noise and into my ear—one only I could hear.

I have plenty I want to say, but we’ll have to save it for later. Don’t you agree?

I belatedly smiled back and nodded. Tang Sadok’s Sound Transmission continued.

Come with me. I’ll take you to the Old Master.

Chapter 840

In the Sichuan Tang Clan, a family built around its bloodline, the Family Head's authority was absolute. No—even if Tang Sadok hadn't been the Family Head, that probably wouldn't have changed much.

The title Myriad-Poison Asura was enough to inspire both awe and fear.

"Our family's Benefactor must be tired after his long journey."

At Tang Sadok's words, the crowd around me naturally began to disperse.

The Sichuan Tang Clan's martial artists, along with the visitors from Emei, Qingcheng, and the Beggars' Sect, saluted Tang Sadok and me before returning to their places. Not without urging us to visit their sects, too.

"So these are the pillars of the Fire Dragon Pavilion I've heard so much about."

Tang Sadok had been taking a good look at the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion while I exchanged greetings with the others. Then he suddenly paused.

"As I understand it, every member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion is young. Have you been struck by some deadly poison?"

Namho, the old young man he'd singled out, answered with a face like he'd bitten into something foul.

"Nothing of the sort."

"If not poison, then qi deviation?"

"You trying to start something with me?"

"Ah, I only asked because I couldn't sense any internal energy. In that case, perhaps your age is…"

"Seventy-five. I'm traveling with these fellows for a while, for reasons of my own."

"My apologies. That was rude of me."

"I understand. We're both getting old. It happens."

Though Namho practiced no martial arts, Tang Sadok regarded his confidence with interest. He showed kindness to Ju Hwaran, granddaughter of the Escort King, and to Song Ilseom, who'd reached an impressive realm at a young age. As for Sama Pyo and Taishan, who strictly speaking belonged to the demonic, heterodox arts, he simply gave them a silent nod.

And then…

"What happened to that fellow?"

"Uh, well. Something happened on the way here."

"It must have been quite something, for his face to swell up that much. Was it Dark Heaven?"

"No. Actually, I hit him a few times."

A brief silence settled over us.

Tang Sadok looked back and forth between me and Hyuk Mujin, who was slung over Taishan's shoulder like a sack of luggage, then sighed.

"I'll have someone look after your subordinates. For now, unpack and visit the Medical Hall in the Outer Court. They'll treat him well."

At Tang Sadok's gesture, a guard waiting nearby came forward. Taishan spoke in his usual flat voice.

"Taishan. And us. Not moving. No—we are not moving. Until Pavilion Master gives the order."

"Ah, of course. There should be food ready for you, too."

"I'll go, then, Pavilion Master. See you later."

"…"

He really was a lunatic.

I mean, if he was going to do that, why say anything in the first place?

I stopped Ju Hwaran with a glance as she started to smack Taishan upside the head, then followed Tang Sadok toward the Inner Court.

"You earn people's trust wherever you go. Here in Sichuan, and even among subordinates who've only recently joined you."

I answered with a quiet laugh. Watching the others slowly disappear from sight, I said, "Seems the same goes for you, Great Hero Tang. I didn't expect them to still be at the Sichuan Tang Clan."

"It's something I'm truly grateful for. I felt ashamed to keep relying on them, so I told them more than once that they were free to go… Yet they've stayed with our family all this time. They're treating the sick who haven't yet recovered and continuing to help rebuild the clan."

"I may not have seen everything, but the Outer Court already looks much as it used to."

"Rebuilding is only an excuse. They're stationed here in case Dark Heaven attacks again. I know that, so I can't bring myself to tell them to leave."

"What?"

"I have to face the truth. If what happened last time happens again while they're gone, I'll have two choices as Family Head: abandon the home our family has built over generations and flee, or make one last stand and see the clan wiped out."

My eyes widened before I could stop them. I hadn't expected the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan—one of the Central Plains' most renowned great clans, famous for its pride—to say such a thing.

Knowing Tang Sadok as I did made it all the more surprising.

"What? Was that more honesty than you expected?"

"Mm. I suppose it was."

“I understand. Especially since you knew what I was like before all this happened.”

“Of course. Back then, you really…had quite a temper.”

“Hah. I was.”

Tang Sadok let out a hearty laugh, and I gaped at him.

“Are you sure you’re feeling all right?”

“I’m perfectly fine. I’ve simply decided to change.”

“Still, be careful. They say when someone changes too suddenly, it means they’re about to die.”

“Hahaha. You’re still honest to a fault. Though that is your greatest charm.”

“Um, sorry, but I have my own preferences.”

“And jokes like that aren’t bad, either.”

“I’m serious.”

“…I take back what I said. You do have a talent for getting under people’s skin.”

Tang Sadok shook his head as we walked on.

We crossed the Outer Court, then the Inner Court, and entered the Rear Court. At some point, the presences that had been following us unseen vanished altogether.

“Is the old—no, is my Master staying in the Rear Court?”

“He is. He arrived two days ago.”

That timing made sense.

I’d woken briefly, then spent three more days asleep. Once Jeok Cheongang understood what had happened, he’d headed for Sichuan without delay. The rest of the party had stayed behind to watch over me while I slept, so naturally they’d traveled more slowly.

“I’m glad he’s still at the Tang Clan. I was worried something might have happened to him.”

“Worried? Have you forgotten what kind of man your Master is?”

“His title sounds terrifying, but once you get to know him, he’s full of holes. He has a surprisingly soft side, too.”

“Huh.”

Tang Sadok let out a disbelieving chuckle.

“You may be the only person in the world who could talk about the Fire King that way. Then again, he cares for you so much that nothing serious has happened even under these circumstances.”

“These circumstances? Did something happen?”

“Well… Never mind. It’ll be quicker if you see for yourself.”

What on earth was going on?

A few things had been bothering me. Jeok Cheongang had come on ahead long ago, yet he was still at the Sichuan Tang Clan. And Tang Sadok had seemed intent on leaving the Fire Dragon Pavilion members behind.

No way…

Unpleasant possibilities flashed through my mind.

Had Dark Heaven attacked Jeok Cheongang while he was traveling alone?

Or had the condition I thought had fully healed worsened after his fight with the Southern Heaven Demon Empress?

Or maybe…

My thoughts were still chasing one another when I spotted a small thatched cottage among the plants and trees of the Rear Court, deep within the Sichuan Tang Clan's grounds.

Then a voice boomed like thunder, reaching my ears from more than a hundred *jang*[3292] away.

"Get up this instant!"

"I'm not getting up! I can't get up!"

"That boy is in danger!"

"There are still patients here who need treatment!"

"He's my Disciple!"

"They're my patients!"

"How many times have I told you that boy's life is in danger if you don't go now?"

"If it were that bad, would I still be here? I heard about his condition and was sure he'd be all right—that's why I said we should wait here! I've told you hundreds of times!"

"No, but you—! I'm telling you, I don't think that's what's going on!"

"A physician makes that judgment, and I'm the physician!"

"One martial artist knows another martial artist's condition best. And I am Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King!"

"My Master is both the Divine Physician and the Slaughter Saint! I inherited his teachings in full, so I know better than you do, Elder!"

"Hey, are you talking back to this old man because you're counting on that man's backing?"

"Oh, so you're going to insult my Master to my face?"

"You insolent brat!"

"You know what? Do your worst! Strike my pressure points, kidnap me—I don't care! But if you drag me away by force, I'll refuse to treat him!"

[3292] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred *jang* is about 303 m (994 ft).

"Would you look at this quack! Fine! I'll count to three! If you don't get up with that damned travel bag by then, you'd better be ready! One!"

"Two, three! Happy?"

"You dare—!"

"Do whatever you like! I'm going to gather herbs!"

Bang!

With that last shout, the cottage door flew open.

An old man came charging out, looking as though he'd kicked the door open himself. He straightened his wildly mussed white hair, fuming.

"As if I don't have enough to do already. Once or twice would be bad enough. I'm so sick of this, I ought to quit!"

Even allowing for the help of internal energy, his voice was loud enough to carry an impressive distance. Naturally, it set off the person who'd been shouting inside.

"Hey! Stop right there! You're barely seventy, you little infant! How dare you! Is that how your Master taught—"

The thunderous voice cut off.

A middle-aged man had rushed out of the cottage, only to freeze when his eyes met mine. A breeze stirred his red hair, making it flicker like flames.

Rustle.

The air grew heavy. The old man, about to snap back, sensed that something was wrong and turned around.

He stared at Tang Sadok and me in silence, then finally spoke.

"Welcome, both of you."

His voice was gentle, his smile as serene as a Daoist immortal's. As if nothing had happened. But I'd seen and heard everything, so I wasn't fooled.

Now I understood what Tang Sadok had meant. I understood why he'd left the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and even the guards behind.

How ugly…!

There was no other word for it. This was too ugly.

Listening to a seventy-year-old Divine Physician and a Fire King over a hundred years old squabble so fiercely made my own heart feel smaller.

If anyone else in Murim had witnessed it, I'd have bet both of Hyuk Mujin's balls that Jeok Cheongang would earn a new title to go with Fire King.

The Disgrace King, Jeok Cheongang…!

It had been so long since I'd seen him. I ought to have been glad. He'd come all this way for me and was roasting the Divine Physician like a peanut; I ought to have been moved. But that wasn't easy.

"Ah, what lovely weather."

Tang Sadok was already gazing at a distant mountain, as though he'd known exactly what was coming. His mutter sounded strangely hollow.

Jeok Cheongang looked at me with somber eyes and spoke in a heavy voice.

"Your body…?"

"I'm fine…"

"How much…did you hear?"

I answered sadly.

"Nothing… I didn't hear anything."

Jeok Cheongang looked up at the clear sky and sighed.

"Fuck. You heard everything…"

The Master and Disciple, reunited after so long, couldn't look each other in the face for a while.

It was summer.

Chapter 841

Tang Sadok led Jeok Cheongang and me to a pavilion deep in the Inner Court and told us to let him know if we needed anything or found anything uncomfortable.

“Then I’ll be going…”

“Wait.”

At Jeok Cheongang’s quiet call, Tang Sadok froze like a statue. Though he still hadn’t recovered, he’d been hurrying to leave the pavilion.

He slowly turned around and struggled to squeeze out a voice that wouldn’t come.

“May I ask why you called me…?”

Jeok Cheongang stared at him in silence, his gaze deep and still. Then he spoke.

“Forget it.”

“Pardon?”

“I said forget it. Everything you’ve seen and heard up to now.”

Myriad-Poison Asura, my ass. The man standing before Tang Sadok was Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King.

The current Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan—a long-established sect of utter thugs who popped up just when people had nearly forgotten them and turned Murim upside down.

For over three hundred years, the sect had gone around setting fires across the land. Yet when his own residence caught fire, Jeok Cheongang had wiped out more than a thousand Demonic Cult members. He was hypocrisy incarnate.

A bead of cold sweat he hadn’t even noticed forming rolled down Tang Sadok’s neck. He swallowed hard and answered.

“O-of course. This junior will forget everything he saw and heard.”

“Forget? You didn’t see or hear anything in the first place. What’s there to forget?”

“Ah.”

“Be careful, all right? Read the room.”

As Jeok Cheongang whispered, he gently massaged Tang Sadok’s neck. Something about the sight was oddly familiar. Then I remembered the high school bullies who used to hang around the alleys when I was in elementary school. They’d acted exactly like that.

The problem was, those bullies had been about seventeen. Jeok Cheongang was at least a hundred and seventeen.

Did he just knock a hundred years off his age?

He clearly wasn’t new to this.

The low voice. The half-lidded eyes. Even his choice of words was perfect for the situation.

"This old man's been in a bit of a bad mood lately. Now, suppose a certain kind of story starts making the rounds in Murim. How do you think I'd feel?"

"I-I think you'd be displeased."

"Not just displeased. It'd ruin my whole day. I'd lose my damn mind."

"I-I'm sorry, Old Master."

"Your late father, the Poison King, and I knew each other reasonably well. I wouldn't say we were close friends, but he was a man I could trust to watch my back."

The Poison King had died a few months earlier at the hands of the Western Heaven Demon Lord, who had been after the Myriad-Poison Ring. He'd been the Grand Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan and Tang Sadok's father. Before that, he'd been one of the Ten Kings, a hero who had helped bring the Great Faction War to a victorious close alongside Jeok Cheongang.

"He had a gloomy streak, but he was smart and quick on the uptake. One day, he poisoned the liquor I was about to drink. Then he saw the Thunderbolt Saber King getting the hell beaten out of him and casually knocked over my cup. Do you know what happened after that?"

Tang Sadok answered hoarsely.

"Yes. You said you'd let it go that once, then suddenly beat my father up three months later…"

"Do you know why I did that?"

"N-no. My father was still wondering about it until a few years ago."

"I was in a foul mood that day, and there was no one else around to hit. So I hit him."

"…!"

"That's the kind of man I am. Starting to get the picture?"

Tang Sadok's jaw dropped. After more than fifty years, he'd finally learned why his father had been beaten up. I opened my mouth on instinct.

"Isn't that just a madman?"

"…"

"…"

"Ah."

A suffocating silence fell. Jeok Cheongang stared at me without a word, then slowly parted his lips.

"Get out."

"What?"

"Get out!"

"Y-yes!"

At Jeok Cheongang's thunderous shout, Tang Sadok looked at me with the relieved expression of a man whose fifty-year-old indigestion had finally cleared up, then shot out of the pavilion like a streak of light.

No—he ran away.

Leaving me behind.

Is he a lizard?

But I could hardly blame him when I'd just made such a huge, spectacular mess all by myself. I steadied my breathing and spoke calmly.

"Old Master, it's a misunderstanding."

"What is?"

"All of it. From beginning to end."

"Our sect's rules say anyone who spouts bullshit from beginning to end gets beaten twice as much."

"…Is that really one of the sect's rules?"

"It is."

"What lunatic—no, what esteemed person came up with that rule?"

"I did. Just now."

Well, I'm fucked.

If excuses weren't going to work, it was time to adapt. I dropped to my knees so fast you'd think Hyuk Mujin had possessed me.

"I'm sorry."

"You're admitting it faster than I expected."

"I've still got a lot of life ahead of me. I can't get beaten to death here."

"Unlike you, this old man doesn't think he has much life left."

"Why not?"

"The brat who's supposed to be my Disciple called me a madman. I ought to go off and die, don't you think?"

I cautiously raised my bowed head. Jeok Cheongang's massive pecs looked like they were at least an E-cup.

He'd regained his youth and sharp mind through Bone Transformation.

Rather than going off somewhere to die, a man built like that could tell everyone except me to drop dead.

"No, Old Master. You'll live a long life. Though you already have."

"I see. But you look like you'll die young."

"Please don't say that. It hurts my feelings."

"I'm the one whose feelings are hurt. I shaved off a perfectly good head of hair and went all the way to Nanman pretending to be a monk, and you dare stab me in the back like this?"

I cautiously raised my head.

Then sunlight poured through the window and flashed off Jeok Cheongang's forehead in a surprise Solar Fist attack. I reflexively squinted.

"Whoa. That's bright."

"…"

"Ah, sorry. And I've always been grateful for how much you care about me, Old Master."

"Too late."

"Someone once said the best time to start is when you think it's too late."

"When you think it's too late, it really is too late. Whoever said that nonsense must've died ages ago."

"Then I'm sorry again."

"Before I do anything, let me ask you one thing."

Jeok Cheongang looked down at me calmly.

"To this old man, you seem closer to a Little Immortal than a human. So if you die, can you come back to life?"

"Why would you ask such a terrifying question…?"

"I'm simply curious."

"But why are you curious about that…?"

"You said you came from the realm of immortals. Surely you must be different in some way."

"I die. I really die."

"Even the you in the realm of immortals?"

"I die there too. I've only got one coin. This was my one and only last life from the start."

"You're saying strange things again."

Come on. Why was he asking me that?

My knees went weak. I sprang to my feet and bowed deeply to Jeok Cheongang. Once didn't seem like enough, so I did it twice.

And as soon as I knelt again, I remembered something I'd briefly forgotten.

"Are you holding a memorial service?"

"Ah."

"Clench your teeth. Let's get this over with."

Whoom.

Before he'd even finished speaking, the air split with a tremendous roar.

I squeezed my eyes shut on instinct and suddenly thought of Hyuk Mujin. If I made it out alive, I resolved to treat him much better than before. Then I gritted my teeth and swallowed a breath.

Hngh…!

And in that instant—

Tap.

Whoosh!

A faint touch brushed my forehead as a fierce gust of hot wind whipped my hair around.

Huh?

As the hot wind died down, I opened my eyes in confusion and saw Jeok Cheongang pressing a finger to my forehead, sighing heavily with an irritated look on his face.

But his eyes held affection, and the joy of seeing me again.

“You little monster. Stop making such a fuss and get up already.”

“What?”

“If you’re going to do it, do it properly. Like…bowing, for instance.”

I blinked dumbly. Jeok Cheongang glanced toward the window, where sunlight streamed in, and muttered:

“Sure is a nice day.”

I didn’t know why I suddenly laughed.

No—that wasn’t true. I already knew.

Today. The day before yesterday. Maybe for a long time now.

“Haha.”

“You little brat. What are you laughing at?”

“Nothing. Let me give you my bow. I’ll make it a proper nine-bow ritual.”

Jeok Cheongang flinched at the mention of the nine-bow ritual, then scoffed.

“We’ve never formally established a Master-Disciple bond. What’s the point of that empty ceremony? Just behave yourself from now on.”

He was right. Jeok Cheongang and I had never formally become Master and Disciple.

An old man who had come out into the world to eliminate the Disciple who had once been like family to him needed a new successor to carry on his sect’s teachings. And a young man struggling to stay alive needed greater strength.

They had come together because each needed what the other had. The nine-bow ritual meant nothing to them. It was an empty ceremony.

Yes. That was how it had been.

But…

It stings a little, hearing him say it.

At some point, what had once felt natural began to sting, and what had stung began to feel natural.

And I wasn’t the only one whose feelings had changed.

“Later.”

A single word reached me.

Jeok Cheongang kept his gaze on the sunlit window. His eyes seemed fixed on something far away.

“When the time comes, if everything returns to its proper place…”

His voice faded and scattered into the breeze.

But I heard him clearly.

The rest of what he’d left unsaid—not with my ears, but with my heart.

And that was enough.

At least for today.

“Old Master.”

“Why are you calling me?”

Jeok Cheongang answered without turning his head. Maybe he couldn’t bring himself to face me.

“Old Master.”

“What? Why?”

His reaction was exactly what I’d expected, and it made me laugh out loud. Then I said the words I’d kept in my heart for a long time.

“It’s good to see you again. And to have you still here, close by.”

“…!”

“I’m back.”

The tension went out of Jeok Cheongang’s rigid shoulders.

He slowly turned to look at me, his expression impossible to read.

As if he’d never once had to decide what face to make at a moment like this, he forced a frown and twisted his lips awkwardly.

But everyone learns through experience.

No matter how much a person denies it, no matter how unfamiliar it feels, they can’t hide what’s in their heart.

That was true even of the man who had lived for more than a century with a hot, hard mask over his face—the face Murim had named the Fire King.

“Wel…”

His voice faltered. His expression was a strange tangle of feelings he still didn’t know what to do with.

But the next moment, his stubborn eyes curved into a gentle arc.

His voice reached me like a soft breeze, as warm as the sunlight.

“Welcome back.”

We smiled at each other.

Chapter 842

The young man woke with a start and blinked.

An unfamiliar ceiling. A strange smell lingering at his nose. And before he could make sense of either, something loomed into view.

“Ugh!”

Wham!

It happened in an instant.

He sat up on instinct, collided with something hard, and fell straight back down.

What was that?

He had no idea.

Not that he cared. It hurt too damn much.

“Urrgh…”

Was this what it felt like to have your face smashed with a rock?

As the young man curled up and groaned, something big and thick flew through his vision, bleached white with pain, and slapped him across the cheek.

Smack.

“Hyukmu. Wake up.”

Smack. Smack.

“Hyukmu. Hyukmu.”

The voice reached him as though from a dream. The young man—Hyuk Mujin—realized who it belonged to.

He also realized that the hard thing he’d struck when he sat up had been that person’s face.

Taishan, you son of a bitch…

No doubt about it. That familiar voice. That inhumanly solid body.

There were plenty of monsters around Hyuk Mujin, but only one who was a monster in the purest sense of the word.

Smack. Smack. Smack.

“Hyukmu, are you all right?”

I’m not all right because of you, you bastard.

Mujin wanted to cry. He’d only blacked out for a moment after the collision, but the lunatic kept slapping him so relentlessly that he couldn’t get up.

“P-please stop…”

“Hyukmuu! Open your eyes!”

Whack!

That one landed squarely. Mujin had barely managed to open his mouth when the blow made him bite his tongue. His body went limp.

As his vision faded, his life flashed before his eyes.

Mother, Father. I'm sorry. You were right.

He should've just taken over the family business like a good son from the start.

By now, he could have been the heir to the Hyuk Family Textile Shop, addressed as Young Master and scattering silver nyang[3293] in the streets. Instead, mouthing off to Jin Taekyung whenever he got the chance and getting punched until his nose bled had become his daily routine.

And now that bastard Taishan is going to beat me to death.

As his vision dimmed, Mujin wondered whether dying like this would count as an accident or a death in battle.

Just as he thought it was all over, he heard a voice like a bell ringing out his salvation.

"Good heavens, Young Hero Taishan! Stop right now!"

The clear voice rang out suddenly. The hand slapping his cheek stopped at once.

"Huh? Uh…"

Taishan blinked his calf-like eyes at Ju Hwaran, who had appeared out of nowhere.

"Taishan waking Hyukmu. Not doing anything bad."

"Not Hyukmu. Hyuk. Hyuk is his surname. And what you were doing looked more like putting him to sleep than waking him."

"That's unfair. Taishan only wanted to help Hyukmu."

"I'm sure you did. If Hyuk Mujin regretted his life and asked you to kill him."

Hwaran sighed quietly and checked Mujin's condition.

Jin Taekyung had once beaten his face until it swelled to twice its size. Now it was three times its size.

"Young Hero Hyuk. Young Hero Hyuk. Can you hear me… Are you crying?"

Realizing he was going to live, Mujin answered through streaming tears.

"No, Young Lady Ju. A real man doesn't cry. Sniff…"

"Should I call you Young Lady Hyuk from now on, then?"

"No, I'd rather you didn't."

"You sound fine, at least. The physician the Tang Family sent earlier must have treated you well."

Song Ilseom, standing beside Hwaran as usual, watched them and muttered, "We may need to call that physician back."

"It's all right. The ointment he left should be enough. He'll recover soon."

Mujin wiped at his tears. "Young Lady Ju, I'm sorry to say this, but I'm not all right."

[3293] A nyang was a traditional Korean unit of weight also used to reckon silver money.

“Finish wiping your tears first. Now, where’s that ointment? Young Hero Taishan, did you see the jar beside the bed?”

“Taishan knows. The one in the little porcelain jar?”

“That’s right. Where is it?”

“Taishan ate it. It was pretty tasty.”

“Oh…”

“Young Lady Ju, please call the physician. I think I’m going to die.”

Hwaran tried to decide who was worse: the man who’d eaten the ointment or the man sniveling and making a fuss. Unable to settle on an answer, she opted to get more ointment.

“Captain Song, I’m sorry, but could you bring me some?”

“No need to apologize. It’s just that this falls outside my duties, so there’ll be an additional fee…”

Song Ilseom noticed Ju Hwaran fiddling with the scabbard at her waist. His face stiffened as he continued.

“…but this doesn’t seem like the time for jokes.”

“Was that a joke?”

“Probably. No, definitely.”

“You’re still here.”

“I’ll be right back.”

Song hurried out. He returned with the ointment before more than a few moments had passed, accompanied by two people who hadn’t been there earlier.

“I brought extra in case that idiot eats it again. Is this enough?”

“I heard Taishan caused more trouble while I was gone. I apologize.”

After Song Ilseom, who was judging the amount of ointment, came Sama Pyo, apologizing. Then Namho asked with an expectant look:

“Just asking, but does the Fire Dragon Pavilion have a rule for offenses like this? Dismemberment into five pieces, perhaps…”

As all three said whatever was on their minds, Hwaran reached for her scabbard again. It had become a habit.

It had started after the Chief Escort she’d trusted like family nearly let the Zhongnan Sect take the Yongbong Escort Bureau, and after everything she’d endured in Nanman.

Hold it together, Hwaran. Just a little longer.

She wanted to draw her sword and go on a mad rampage. Instead, she took a deep breath, gathered the last of her patience, and answered them in turn.

“That’s plenty of ointment. Young Hero Sama, don’t leave in the first place. Taishan would probably cause some other trouble even with you here, but at least he

wouldn't eat the ointment or knock Hyuk Mujin unconscious again. And Old Master Namho."

"Yes?"

"If you want to deal with Taishan so badly, do it yourself. We're at the Sichuan Tang Clan. See if you can find some poison."

"…"

"…"

"…"

"What? Does anyone else have something to say?"

Her icy voice made everyone in the room shut their mouths and shake their heads.

Even Taishan, one of the most oblivious men alive, and Mujin, who had been moaning in pain, fell silent. They traded glances with the others.

Young Lady Ju has changed a lot. She's had a hard time lately, but I didn't think it was this bad. That man's supposed to be her escort. Doesn't he know anything?

Why is that unorthodox bastard staring at me? Does he want a real fight this time?

Good heavens. I thought I'd gained a sweet little granddaughter in my old age. How did she turn out like this? Then again, dismemberment was a bit much. I should look for poison, as she suggested.

Taishan wants more ointment. It was a nice little treat.

These damn people don't care that I'm hurt at all. And what does she mean, the Sichuan Tang Clan? What the hell happened?

Not a single thought got through to anyone else, but everyone except Hwaran reached the same unspoken agreement: they would keep their mouths shut until she calmed down.

It wasn't until Ju Hwaran's stiff face softened that Hyuk Mujin, who'd been furtively checking the others' expressions while applying ointment himself, was able to hear what had happened.

"What? It's been two days?"

Hwaran nodded. "Exactly two days."

"Then this really is…"

"As I told you, we're at the Sichuan Tang Clan. More precisely, in the Medical Hall of its Outer Court."

Mujin could only blink.

He'd closed his eyes for what felt like a short, deep sleep. Now two days had passed, and he'd woken in the Sichuan Tang Clan's Medical Hall.

"What on earth happened?"

"Young Hero Hyuk, you don't remember?"

"No. I only remember what the Captain and the Huang tribe member were saying at the river landing. After that, there was a flash before my eyes."

Song Ilseom, leaning against the wall with his arms crossed, muttered, “You remember it exactly.”

“What? That’s it?”

“Yes. None of us got a clear look at what happened.”

Sama Pyo nodded without thinking, then added, “The punch was unbelievably fast. I’ve never seen one like it. Something blurred, there was a sound like a drum bursting, and you fell. That was all.”

“Lord is wrong. That’s not all. Taishan saw everything. From start to finish.”

Taishan cut in, shuddering.

“Pavilion Master beat Hyukmu. Beat him a lot. Beat the fucking hell out of him.”

“…”

“Hyukmu was already down. Pavilion Master stomped on him. Stomped and stomped, like mincing meat. Ah, Taishan wants meat.”

“…”

“Oh, Pavilion Master tried to stomp on his pepper too, but people stopped him. Taishan helped stop him. No one should do that. Ah, Taishan wants Sichuan-style five-spice pork with lots of pepper.”

From a corner of the Medical Hall, where he sat puffing on his long-stemmed tobacco pipe, Namho groaned.

“Fuck’s sake. I told you we should dismember him into five pieces.”

“Taishan doesn’t know what that means. Namho know?”

“Of course I do. You tie bastards like a certain someone to oxen or horses, then pull their arms and legs right off—”

“Oh! Taishan gets the leg meat!”

Crack.

Namho snapped his pipe and charged at Taishan with a roar like a wild beast. Sama Pyo caught him and held him back as he struggled.

Hwaran sighed. “Anyway, that’s what happened. That part of you is safe, so you don’t need to check it now.”

Mujin had seized on the commotion to make a frantic check of his most important parts. He answered weakly, “That’s a relief. Where’s the Captain?”

“With Great Hero Jeok.”

“What? For the whole two days?”

“Yes. They seem to have a lot to talk about. I don’t know exactly what.”

“But they were together not long ago. What could take two days to talk about?”

“They haven’t told us, so we can only guess. I heard the Divine Physician is making a pill for the Pavilion Master. Perhaps it isn’t just talk. They may be preparing to help him recover.”

Hwaran’s guess sounded reasonable enough. Mujin nodded.

“True. It’s not as if he’s come back from some faraway land. How much could they possibly have to talk about? Don’t you all agree?”

When you come back from a faraway land, you have plenty to talk about.

Especially when all sorts of unimaginable things have been happening there.

After I’d told Jeok Cheongang my endless story, he stayed silent for a long while.

Then he summed up his thoughts in a single, short, blunt remark.

“We’re fucked.”

Chapter 843

Jeok Cheongang was a giant who had left his footprints in the vast sandpit of Murim.

He might not admit it himself, but everyone who had ever set foot in Murim thought so.

He was the Fire King, a great martial artist who had survived countless wars and crises over more than a hundred years.

The strong inspired awe. Old veterans earned respect. Jeok Cheongang was one of the few who commanded both.

His martial prowess placed him among the ten strongest people in the world, and no one could guess the depths of his experience and knowledge.

But even Jeok Cheongang didn't know everything about the world he'd lived in for more than a hundred years.

Much less a world that wasn't *this* one.

"We're fucked."

After a long silence, Jeok Cheongang spat out those words, certain that if everything he'd heard was true, there was no better way to put it.

The young man sitting across from him nodded.

"Yes. You've got it exactly right, Old Master."

Jin Taekyung clicked his tongue bitterly.

We're fucked. Nothing else quite captured how bad things were in the modern world.

One disaster after another had erupted without pause.

Looking back, Lee Jungryong seemed like a fairy. Michael Silbert and the Doppelganger had spent more than thirty years working together to bring the whole world to the brink of chaos.

No—the chaos had already begun in earnest.

"So, what was it called?"

"Monsters."

"Right. Mosu-tuh. Those Demonic Cult-like bastards are coming in force to the realm of immortals where you live, is that it?"

"Yes. Just like they did thirty years ago."

This wasn't the first time Jeok Cheongang had heard about it.

Taekyung had told him once, right after they left the Nanman Beast Palace, and again over the past two days.

But even with a far more detailed explanation this time, Jeok Cheongang struggled to understand what he'd heard. Another twenty explanations wouldn't have helped.

How could such a place exist?

A distant world no one could reach, no matter how many decades or centuries they walked. An unknown land they would never see, even after crossing mountains and seas.

And that wasn't all.

People there could talk face-to-face from tens of thousands of li[3294] apart, while enormous birds made of steel flew above the clouds.

Jeok Cheongang had spent his life walking through a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords. No wonder every new detail filled him with amazement and disbelief.

If anyone else had told him all this, he'd have slapped them across the face and burned them to a crisp with Flame Divine Palm.

Even if it had been the Martial God or the Son of Heaven.

But…

That brat's the one telling me. I have to believe him.

Believe him. Jin Taekyung.

At some point, that had become the most natural thing in the world. The old man trusted the young man, and the young man trusted the old man.

Jeok Cheongang didn't know when it had happened, but they had become the kind of people who would take even the most unbelievable nonsense from each other as fact.

"If the Dharma King, that damned monk, were alive and here with us, he'd have fainted dead away. He spent every day staring up at the stars, but do you think he ever imagined anything like this?"

Thinking of his departed friend, Jeok Cheongang looked at Taekyung.

"The more I hear, the less I understand that world. And yet, in a way, it's much like this one. Don't you think?"

Taekyung nodded.

At first, everything around him had felt unfamiliar and different. But not anymore.

The modern world and Murim. Murim and the modern world.

The two worlds were astonishingly alike—not in their civilizations, but in the currents of change running through them.

"If Murim has Dark Heaven, then the world I lived in has monsters. And both are headed in a bad direction."

"Not so long ago, each world went through its own Great Faction War, too."

"That's right."

"Then you…"

[3294] A Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi).

Jeok Cheongang trailed off. When he continued, his voice was grave.

Do you think all of this is just a coincidence?

A short silence fell.

As Jin Taekyung gazed at the oil lamp flickering in the darkness, his eyes began to glow red.

It was late enough that even the stars had fallen asleep.

I left Jeok Cheongang behind, stepped out of the pavilion, and wandered alone through the Inner Court. I had no destination in mind. All I carried was the question he'd just asked.

Do you think all of this is just a coincidence?

If Jeok Cheongang had asked me anything more specific, I would've hesitated to answer.

There was so much even I still didn't know. So many secrets remained hidden in both worlds.

But I was certain of my answer to that question.

Not at all.

It wasn't a coincidence.

That was what I'd told him after a short silence. It had taken me a long time to become sure of it.

I'd been thinking about it ever since I first opened my eyes in Murim. And after all that time, I'd reached one conclusion.

There's a connection. A definite connection.

At first, everything that happened to me had felt like a terrible run of bad luck.

All I'd done was fall asleep in a damn old capsule. Then I'd had to fight one danger after another in a world where I couldn't even tell whether it was a game or reality.

But as my circumstances changed, so did my thinking.

I'd gone from an F-rank Hunter who lost his job overnight to a celebrity, gripping power and wealth in both hands that I never could've imagined before.

And I'd gained them in both worlds—the modern world and Murim.

My bad luck turned into good luck.

The days when I'd lamented, *How can I be this unlucky?* quickly faded into the past.

What I'd thought was bad luck turned out to be good fortune sent down from the heavens. Maybe it was even more than that—a stroke of heavenly fortune.

Until, one day, I began to feel a strange sense of déjà vu.

From Shanxi Province to Henan. Across Sichuan and all the way to Hubei.

Beneath the dark clouds of Dark Heaven, blood-soaked flames had risen.

The Head Elder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who had long harbored a desire for revenge, drew the sword he'd kept hidden for years. A revered monk, respected for his extraordinary martial prowess and wisdom, met his death. And the flames that swept through Shaolin Temple spread to Sichuan and Hubei.

And finally, they reached distant Nanman.

The one saving grace was that those flames hadn't reduced everything in their path to ash.

Though countless people had died, even more had escaped the fire. And I'd found many traces left behind where that terrible disaster had swept through.

The Water God Dragon, driven mad and stripped of reason.

Fishermen and fish transformed into grotesque creatures that looked like monsters.

Dark Heaven's Moving Formation, so much like modern Teleport Magic that I couldn't dismiss it as mere dark arts or a formation.

And finally…

The rift that opened in Nanman.

I remembered it clearly. No—I couldn't forget it.

That darkness writhing like a living creature. The familiarity I'd sensed time and again in what Murim's martial artists called demonic qi.

It was magical power. I'm sure of it.

At first, I couldn't accept that.

It shouldn't exist. It couldn't exist.

But as time passed, the picture grew clearer, forcing me to face reality.

It isn't just a difference in names.

Mana and internal energy were identical at their core. Both were qi.

Something everywhere and nowhere at once. An intangible force present in blue seas and forests, and in smog-filled canyons of skyscrapers, though most people couldn't sense it.

Magical power was different.

That evil energy, steeped in death, had flowed in from another world.

If mana and internal energy were natives, present from the beginning, then magical power was a stranger—an invader that had crossed over from beyond along with the monsters.

And now that very magical power had appeared.

Not in the modern world, but here in Murim.

How am I supposed to make sense of that?

Ha.

A hollow laugh escaped me.

How was I supposed to make sense of it? I could try to deny it all I wanted, but I couldn't ignore what was right in front of me. I already knew the answer.

Dark Heaven.

There was no doubt.

Dark Heaven was the true link between the modern world and Murim.

Everything I'd personally witnessed since becoming entangled with them was evidence—and served as both prosecutor and judge.

But how?

How had they set foot in this world—in Murim?

The Great Faction War had been a major event, but in the end, it was a war over supremacy in Murim.

If anything like the Great Cataclysm had happened, I would've known. Or at least Jeok Cheongang and the others who'd lived through that time would have.

Rumors of hideous monsters sweeping across the land would've reached even the most remote villages.

But all anyone knows is that Dark Heaven succeeded the Demonic Cult and uses strange dark arts.

The implication was clear.

Something that shouldn't exist appeared in Murim during the chaos of the Great Faction War—or shortly afterward.

If so, the timing lined up exactly. That was when Dark Heaven first approached the Head Elder.

But I still didn't know the underlying cause. The biggest question remained unanswered.

The Lord of Heaven.

Dark Heaven's master.

No, an absolute being they might as well worship as a god.

How he could exist in Murim wasn't what puzzled me. The Great Cataclysm thirty-odd years ago had begun much the same way.

The problem was…

Who the Lord of Heaven really is.

Step.

I stopped walking.

Darkness lay heavy over the world, and torches burned red throughout the Inner Court.

As I stared blankly into their flames, lost in thought, I suddenly felt a shock as if something had pierced through the top of my head.

"Could it be…?"

The words escaped me like a groan and faded into the darkness.

Just then—

Swish.

The shadow cast by a wavering torch touched the tips of my feet.

Like that cursed being who no longer existed. Like the one who had smiled even as he met his eternal Erasure.

And at the same time, a conversation buried in the depths of my memories rang in my ears like an illusion.

The great king has overcome a god's curse. He may waver, but he will not break. Even if he falls, he will rise again. And at last, he will make all the earth and water in this world his own.

What?

That alone is the truth. A truth you cannot stop even knowing it—a truth that will become reality before long.

"…!"

I froze like a statue, as though I were back in that moment when I'd faced the Doppelganger.

Chapter 844

“Is that it?”

The man who spoke looked to be around thirty at most. His face was ordinary—the kind you might see several times in a day at the marketplace.

Yet no one would dare look at him and think he was ordinary.

He wasn’t standing in a marketplace. He was standing in a pool of dark-red blood.

“It’s certainly improved, but it’s still nowhere near what I expected…”

Crunch.

He stepped on an arm half-submerged in the blood and continued.

“Did you call me here just to show me this?”

The owner of the arm? He didn’t know. He had no need to know.

It belonged to one of countless test subjects, one of the dozens he had killed here today.

The problem was that he wasn’t particularly pleased with the experiment’s results.

“You’ve all got mouths. Say something, will you?”

The black-robed men lined up before him swallowed dryly in the icy silence.

They knew the man all too well. Whenever his temper soured, blood was sure to follow. Some of their own comrades had died that way.

After witnessing it countless times, who would dare open their mouth?

Their silence was a lesson learned through repetition. But for all the man’s brutality, he wasn’t stupid.

“Hah. Look at you lot. I call you sorcerers and treat you like people, and this is what I get…”

He gave a short laugh. The next instant, his figure blurred.

Thud.

Flesh and brain matter flew in every direction. One of the black-robed men—or rather, one of the sorcerers—crumpled like a rotten tree, his head smashed to pieces.

Boom.

The thunderous sound told the sorcerers what they had to do.

Thump.

They dropped to their knees without hesitation.

Silence wasn’t the only lesson they’d learned. They also knew that however cruel the man was, he preferred not to spill more of *their* blood than necessary.

“P-please, calm your anger.”

“Blood Lord…!”

The man—the Blood Lord—looked down at the sorcerers as they cried out and knocked their heads against the stone floor. A faint bloody light glowed in his eyes.

Vermin.

He wanted to tear their limbs off right then and there, but he forced down the urge to kill them.

Western Heaven is dead, and now Southern Heaven too. We need to preserve every bit of strength we can if we're to accomplish the great cause.

Sorcerers were precious. Few in Dark Heaven could wield supernatural powers, and the research they'd pursued for years was bearing considerable fruit.

Today's results simply hadn't pleased him.

Once they produced something close to a finished result, its impact would be more than enough to swallow the world.

"Not enough. Still not enough."

At the words he seemed to have spoken to himself, the sorcerers bowed their heads even lower.

If it wasn't enough, they would have to make up the difference somehow. They didn't want to end up like their comrades who had died before them.

"Blood Lord, if you could tell us which part you found lacking…"

"Every part of it."

The Blood Lord turned slowly and gestured toward the bodies scattered around them.

"They were all too weak. And the duration still hasn't improved."

"We're looking for ways to improve them, but we're nowhere near able to increase the potency of both effects at once. Obtaining enough Peak masters is just as difficult."

The Blood Lord frowned at what sounded like an excuse, but this time he had to accept it.

Peak masters couldn't be made overnight.

Even at the great sects of the Central Plains, which accepted only exceptional talent, reaching the Peak realm took more than ten years of grueling training.

The time varied with talent and effort, but that was all. Even demonic, heterodox martial arts, which could be mastered far faster than those of the orthodox faction, were no exception.

Nothing came easily. Those martial arts lacked purity and depth, and countless practitioners faltered before the wall of the Peak realm.

Those two were the exceptions.

The Blood Lord bit his lip. He couldn't bring himself to say it aloud.

As he recalled the not-so-distant past, a bloody gleam flickered in his eyes.

Jin Taekyung. Cheongpung.

At first, he'd thought they were earthworms. Creatures that would pop with a little pressure from his foot.

But at some point, those two earth dragons had become heavenly dragons. They'd risen from a mud pit full of filth and flown into the blue sky.

No. At least one of them was never an earthworm to begin with.

Even the Blood Lord had to admit that comparing Cheongpung to an earthworm might have been too harsh.

The youngest Disciple Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had accepted in his later years. A martial talent bestowed by the heavens.

Cheongpung was a genius whose equal was hard to find in Murim's history, born with the destiny of a dragon.

But…

What the hell is Jin Taekyung?

The Blood Lord had been the power behind Jin Yangbaek, Head Elder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. He remembered all too clearly the day he'd first received a report on Jin Taekyung, long ago.

He remembered the first thing he'd said to the subordinate who delivered it, too.

"Investigate him again."

"Pardon?"

"How can anyone be that fucking useless? There must be something he's hiding."

It was only natural.

Jin Taekyung's martial arts were worse than a Third Rate street thug's, and he even made a schedule for his rounds of the pleasure houses.

If the eldest son, struggling to restore the family's fortunes, and the second, training day and night, were the pillars of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Jin Taekyung was gnawing at what remained of them from the roots up.

An earthworm.

No. A bug.

But one day, Jin Taekyung changed.

Unlike Cheongpung, Jin Taekyung had been born a bug. Then he became an earthworm, then a venomous centipede, then an imugi,[3295] and finally a dragon.

When the Blood Lord pieced together the entire transformation, he was stunned.

That bastard has gone far beyond anything that makes sense.

Cheongpung was born with the destiny of a dragon. There was nothing strange about calling him one now.

Jin Taekyung had been granted no such destiny by the heavens.

[3295] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpentine being associated with becoming a dragon.

He was nothing but a bug, an earthworm. All he could do when stepped on was writhe.

That should have been all.

Throb.

A sudden pain made the Blood Lord clench his teeth.

He looked down at his arms. Both were whole and attached. Someone's purplish Force had once severed them, but they had grown back stronger than before. Now they trembled faintly.

From fear? No. This was anger.

And pain and humiliation etched into his soul.

If Jin Taekyung hadn't gotten in my way…

The Blood Lord ground his teeth as he recalled that day: Jin Taekyung, drenched in blood, clinging to his ankle and refusing to let go—and the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's Force sweeping across his arm.

Worse than the pain had been the ridicule of the others.

Though two of them were lonely spirits now.

Western Heaven. Southern Heaven. Watch closely from wherever you are. I'll accomplish what you two failed to do.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had been too powerful for even the prideful Blood Lord to dismiss.

Their deaths were an enormous loss to Dark Heaven, but they had taught him two lessons.

First, he must never let his guard down against Jin Taekyung.

Second, helping the Lord of Heaven accomplish the great cause would require greater strength and effort than ever before.

"Spread them."

"What?"

The Blood Lord looked at the sorcerers who had questioned him without thinking. The bloody gleam that had been in his eyes moments ago had settled into a cold stare.

"Now that the Great War has begun, we need to gather every bit of strength we can. We can't keep using Peak masters in experiments like these forever."

"You mean…"

"You've already planted seeds throughout the Central Plains. Am I wrong?"

The head of the sorcerers bowed deeply.

"No. Some of the seeds have already blossomed."

It was true.

With vast wealth and years of research, Dark Heaven had created the "seeds" and scattered some of them throughout the land long ago.

Some had gone to Henan and Shaanxi, at the heart of orthodox Murim. Others had gone to border regions such as Guangxi and Guangdong.

And some… to the northern plateau bordering Shanxi Province.

The seeds were both an experiment and a means of sowing chaos across Central Plains Murim. Barely a month ago, one had nearly shaken an entire city.

Nearly.

"You failed spectacularly in Guangxi Province."

"That was…"

"I know. If the Fire King—that old man—hadn't happened to show up pretending to be a monk, it might have worked."

The unorthodox faction's uprising in Guangxi Province had been no coincidence.

A man carrying a "seed" had gathered followers and seized control of half of Guangxi.

At least until Jeok Cheongang, hiding his identity under the sobriquet Blood Monk, had smashed his head.

"But those were failures made before we improved the effects. If the ones we have now fall into the wrong hands…"

"It doesn't matter."

The Blood Lord cut off the sorcerer's warning that the blade might turn against them.

"Select men fit to become seeds and bury them deep. Make sure they can be spread whenever the time comes."

The sorcerers could see that further objections were useless.

They had two choices: obey or die.

And the Blood Lord wasn't wrong. They chose to obey.

"As you command."

The Blood Lord's eyes flashed as he looked down at their bowed heads.

He could still recall every word of his conversation with the Lord of Heaven, who had awakened without warning from his long slumber just ten days ago.

"The time has come."

"Lord of Heaven, what do you mean?"

"The world is twisting. Now… bring down the heavens."

The Blood Lord drew a long breath.

After issuing that one command, the Lord of Heaven had fallen asleep again. He had given his faithful servant an unbelievable opportunity: the chance to draw the bowstring in his name.

And now the Blood Lord knew by instinct.

It was time to release it.

"Send out missives."

That day, dozens of black-feathered hawks took to the sky.

Chapter 845

“Chew it thoroughly before you swallow.”

“Chew it?”

“Yes. Don’t swallow it whole, and don’t spit it out halfway through. Understood?”

The Divine Physician had arrived at first light with that stern warning. I gave a faint laugh and accepted the pill he held out.

“Of course. I’m not a child, and you made it for my sake.”

The pill was dark and about the size of a marble.

The Appraisal System was still inaccessible, so I couldn’t tell exactly what was in it or what it would do. But the Divine Physician must have spent several sleepless nights making it. The exhaustion around his eyes was proof enough.

He must have had plenty of other patients to care for, too.

The best physician in the world had sacrificed his own time and health to make this pill for me. Even if it was hard as a rock, I planned to chew it until the sweetness came out. It was the least I could do.

And the moment I chewed the pill with heartfelt gratitude—

Crunch.

I realized that being a decent human being could go to hell. This wasn’t something a human being could eat.

Ptooey.

The pill I spat out on instinct stuck fast to the Divine Physician’s pristine white robe.

He gazed mournfully at the pill he’d spent days making. “I told you not to spit it out…”

Still retching and struggling to keep my senses, I spoke from the heart.

“Sorry, but are you out of your mind?”

“I am, and I understand exactly how you feel.”

“Have you tried eating it yourself?”

“I haven’t.”

“Then you have no idea how I feel. None.”

“Medicine that’s good for you is supposed to taste bitter. It always is.”

“This wasn’t just bitter. Did you put poison in it or something?”

“Enough!”

Jeok Cheongang, who’d watched the whole thing, bellowed and glared at me.

“He may not be particularly trustworthy and may seem a bit of a quack, but he made that medicine with care for your sake. Poison? Where did you get the nerve to say such blasphemous nonsense?”

"Sorry."

"Don't apologize to me. Apologize to that quack!"

"Sorry, elder. I misspoke."

The Divine Physician, who was apparently neither particularly trustworthy nor entirely unlike a quack, looked silently between us.

I could almost feel how badly he wanted to stab one of us with a large acupuncture needle. Fortunately, his martial arts weren't up to the task. His sobriquet was Divine Physician, not Divine Needle.

He drew a deep breath, as if suppressing the urge to kill, and spoke calmly.

"It's all right. I've devoted the rest of my life to medicine. A physician must put up with unfair and filthy treatment while caring for a patient, mustn't he?"

"…"

"…"

"Sometimes I do wonder what my Master would think if he were here, but it's all right. I'm a physician, after all. I should expect a pill I spent several sleepless nights making to be chewed up and spat out. Ha ha ha."

He did not look all right.

His words didn't merely have a barb in them. They had an acupuncture needle the size of an awl hidden inside.

Jeok Cheongang and I watched his face and quietly exchanged Sound Transmission.

—This is all your fault.

—If you hadn't butted in, it wouldn't have come to this.

—You asked a physician who'd brought you medicine whether he put poison in it. Is that any way for a human being to talk?

—Is calling him a quack any better?

—Why wouldn't it be?

—He's the Divine Physician. He might take offense.

—I'm the Fire King.

—I'm the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

—How dare a little fucking nobody like you compare yourself to me?

—…

—Anyway, shut up and eat it. It's all for your sake.

A little fucking nobody? That hurt.

Jeok Cheongang shot me a fierce glare, then made an effort to soften his voice as he addressed the Divine Physician.

"Don't take it to heart. I'll give the boy a proper scolding."

"Then who's going to scold Sir Jeok…?"

"Hm? What was that?"

"Nothing. I misspoke."

Lying through his teeth, the Divine Physician peeled the pill off his robe. He stared mournfully at the clear tooth marks I'd left in it and sighed.

"Some of its medicinal properties have leaked out, but it's not too late. This time, chew it well and swallow it."

One thing was certain: its medicinal properties weren't the only thing leaking out.

Jeok Cheongang caught a whiff of the hideous stench escaping from the crushed pill and instinctively stepped back.

"Could this be Formless Ultimate Poison…!"

"I'm done treating him. I'll throw this pill in the latrine. Find another physician."

"W-wait!"

The Fire King caught the Divine Physician's robe as he turned away and spoke through his nose. His other hand had already flashed up to pinch it shut.

"Ah, I didn't mean to do that. Sorry. But this stench… What in the world did you put in this pill?"

"If I told you, would you understand?"

"…"

"It's a secret method my Master taught me. Stop asking and let it go. And don't worry—it isn't poison."

The Jeok Cheongang I knew would have answered with a spectacular string of curses and a blazing Flame Divine Palm. But for now, the Divine Physician held all the cards.

As patient and guardian, we kept our mouths shut and nodded. Jeok Cheongang urged me on, looking equal parts worried and curious.

"Do as he says. I'm here, so don't worry about what happens afterward."

"…"

Put like that, it really did sound as if I was about to swallow Formless Ultimate Poison.

I gave him a resentful look, then squeezed my eyes shut. Blocking out my senses as best I could, I tossed the pill into my mouth.

Crunch, crunch, crunch.

My jaw worked without pause. I curled my tongue as tightly as I could to avoid tasting anything. Then I added a spoonful of desperate effort to keep from retching.

Hnnngh.

I felt like I was going to die. No, I wouldn't have been surprised if I was already dead.

A hideous stench burst through my mouth with every chew. As some unidentified, thick juice trickled down my throat, my esophagus started doing the Zero Two[3296] and my guts launched into the cocaine dance.[3297]

Urgh, shit…!

I swear, I'd never encountered a stench or anything so revolting in my life.

Not even when I was a rookie Hunter and fell nose-first into a goblin's armpit inside a Gate. Not even when I screamed and flailed so wildly that I accidentally burst the creature's balls with my bare hand.

"Urk! Uuugh!"

Reason deserted me. My body moved on instinct.

Bent over like a shrimp, I tried to vomit up something hot surging from deep in my stomach.

Tried to.

If someone hadn't clamped a hand over my mouth and nose at that very moment —

Crack.

My breath caught. I struggled on reflex, but the grip holding me fast stuck like glue.

And there was only one person here who could restrain me so completely.

Old Master?

I forced open the eyes I'd squeezed shut and saw Jeok Cheongang's eyes glowing red with Scorching Yang Qi.

Then a powerful blow struck my Adam's apple.

Thwack!

With his hand sealed over my mouth and nose, I couldn't even scream.

As my newly brightened vision went black, I thought, *At this point, that's closer to poison than medicine.*

That was it.

I felt the finely crushed pill mix with my saliva and flow deep into my body. Then I lost consciousness.

Whoosh.

Along with a heat I knew better than anything.

Jeok Cheongang neither panicked nor hesitated.

[3296] The Zero Two dance is an internet dance meme associated with the anime *Darling in the Franxx*.

[3297] The cocaine dance is a South Korean internet dance meme.

He had lived for a hundred and several dozen years. The age of fifty, when a man came to understand Heaven's will and the natural order, lay far behind him. He knew better than anyone what he had to do.

Now.

Scorching Yang Qi seethed through his body, but his mind was as cold as year-round snow.

All trace of his earlier banter gone, he reached toward the unconscious Jin Taekyung, his face grave.

Swish. Tap. Dudududuk!

His movements were as swift as a flash of light, his hands terrifyingly calm.

Every time they blurred, Jin Taekyung's body jerked. Scorching Yang Qi seeped in with each Pressure-Point Strike, melting the pill and spreading its medicinal effects throughout Jin's body.

Don't rush. Stay calm.

Jeok Cheongang repeated the words to himself as if making a vow.

He couldn't afford the slightest mistake. Humans weren't so easy to kill, but their bodies were astonishingly sensitive. All the more so when that body held several jiazi[3298] of internal energy.

Rumble.

Tremendous heat surged around them. The solid wooden floor of the pavilion charred black, and the two men were surrounded by a shimmer like a desert mirage.

Hssssss.

An ordinary physician witnessing the scene would have rubbed his eyes or screamed and fled.

But the Divine Physician was the one physician who did neither.

He had spent decades following his Master and treating countless patients, and his Master's excellent teaching had given him experience beyond even that. It mattered, too, that the Master in question was the Slaughter Saint.

It's going as smoothly as it possibly could. Hard to believe, considering the treatment he's performing.

The Divine Physician watched Jeok Cheongang in wonder.

Working the channels and pressure points was no easy undertaking. The practitioner had to sweep, strike, press, and tap hundreds of points across the body, opening blocked flows of qi and blood and loosening knotted muscles.

That alone consumed enormous concentration and internal energy. A single mistake could seriously injure the practitioner, too.

And this time, he has to spread the pill's energy to every corner of the body.

[3298] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

It wasn't merely difficult. It was extraordinarily difficult.

Under normal circumstances, even the Divine Physician wouldn't have dared treat someone this way.

With the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, it was different. Of the ten Supreme Peak masters known as kings throughout the world, he alone could be compared to the Three Saints. He was also a Master willing to risk anything for his only Disciple.

Just like the Divine Physician's own Master.

You're doing well somewhere, aren't you? Aren't you?

The Divine Physician had just thought of the Master he'd parted from four months earlier, almost as if he'd been forced to leave, and smiled faintly when—

Whoosh.

The heat and haze slowly dispersed. Through them, Jeok Cheongang came into view, rising to his feet, his face a little pale.

"Sir Jeok. Are you all right?"

"Don't make a fuss. This much won't hurt me."

"Even so, you should at least—"

"I'm fine. See to that reckless brat first."

From what the Divine Physician had witnessed, the treatment had been flawless. Yet even after pouring so much into it, Jeok Cheongang still worried.

His insistence that the Divine Physician check Jin again seemed driven less by trust in the physician than by boundless affection for his Disciple.

And the Divine Physician understood Jeok Cheongang's feelings.

"Understood. I'll examine him again."

He went to Jin Taekyung, who lay unconscious, and took his pulse. He was so thorough that half an hour had passed by the time he looked up.

"It's done. The pill's medicinal effects have been fully absorbed."

Only then did life return to Jeok Cheongang's tired eyes.

"Does that mean…?"

"I'm sorry. He's still a long way from a full recovery. In fact, I can't promise he'll ever recover completely."

"What?"

"You already know, Sir Jeok. His vital essence has been damaged."

"…!"

"Even steel bends when it's heated. In the end, it becomes a lump of molten metal. What chance does a body made of flesh and blood have?"

The Divine Physician looked at Jeok Cheongang gravely. It was hard to meet his trembling gaze, but a physician who lied about a patient's condition was no physician at all.

“Making this pill made me realize it once again. A full recovery is impossible, but improvement is possible.”

Grind.

Jeok Cheongang clenched his teeth.

He had suspected as much since Nanman. But it was a truth he couldn’t bear to face.

You foolish… foolish boy.

What in the world had happened? How fiercely had Jin fought, again and again, in that place as it became a hellscape?

Jeok Cheongang’s eyes trembled as he watched Jin Taekyung, now sleeping peacefully.

Then—

Crash!

The door flew open, and the rough beat of horses’ hooves sounded beyond the window.

Chapter 846

Dudududududu!

Some twenty horsemen galloped without slowing. The faces beneath their low-pulled helmets were tense, and white foam had dried around the mouths of their panting horses. Not one rider eased the reins.

Not until they reached their destination, enclosed by stone walls like a fortress.

The first thing to greet them was a wary shout.

“Stop!”

It happened in an instant. At the shout from atop the stone wall, a dozen or so arrows flashed through the air and pierced the plumes on the horsemen’s helmets.

Shaaak! Thunk, thunk, thunk!

The accuracy was almost supernatural, the force tremendous. The horsemen stared at the arrows quivering where they’d struck the ground.

A mistake?

No. A warning.

If they ignored the warning and came any closer, the next arrows would pierce their throats instead of their helmet plumes.

“Gasp…!”

Sighs erupted from all around.

The more than twenty horsemen stopped where they stood as if on cue. They couldn’t hide their fear, but the man at their center was different.

As expected. The reputation is well deserved.

He looked up at the wall, admiration and tension mingling in his eyes. A group of archers stood there with bows drawn, backlit by the early morning sun.

Above their green martial robes fluttered a banner bearing four characters written in a single flowing stroke.

Sichuan Tang Clan.

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families. Fifteen pillars supporting Murim as it stood today.

And among them, none had a reputation for being more closed-off or cunning.

But…

He’s here. Right here.

The man steeled himself and stepped forward alone. Rather than a sturdy shield against the arrows that might fly at any moment, he held high a silver token drawn from his robes.

“Don’t attack! I’ve come from Seongju Prefecture!”

“Who did you say you were?”

“Huang. I’m the City Lord’s Captain of the Guards.”

“The City Lord? Ah, that fellow who’s been wasting away?”

“…I don’t know who you are, but you’d do well to watch your tongue.”

“If you don’t know who I am, you’re the one who should watch his tongue. You look like you’ve spent a fair bit of time in Murim. How have you not figured out something that simple?”

The Captain of the Guards swallowed before he realized he was doing it.

The man had plainly been picking a fight, yet somehow the captain didn’t feel offended. No—the man’s bearing made it seem only natural that he should speak that way.

Who is he?

For a moment, the Captain of the Guards forgot his mission and studied the man in front of him.

He wasn’t quite a giant, but he had a sturdy, well-proportioned build and a face that looked around forty. So far, he could have been any martial artist in Murim.

But his gaze was so piercing it bordered on menacing. Even the Captain of the Guards, who’d seen all sorts of people since his days as a wandering martial artist, flinched.

And he’s bald.

The Captain of the Guards saw the middle-aged man’s scalp gleaming in the sunlight and sensed danger.

In his experience, most martial artists were missing something important. Why would anyone who was carefree and happy throw himself into the brutal, turbulent martial world?

The bald ones he remembered were especially unpredictable. They were missing something inside, just like the others—but, unfairly, they were missing their hair as well.

“Hey.”

“Yes?”

The captain jumped and answered on reflex. He’d slipped from polite speech into outright deference so naturally that he hadn’t noticed it himself.

“You know me?”

“N-no.”

“Then why are you staring at my head like that? It’s making me uncomfortable.”

It was hard to say which was ruder: calling someone “you” and “that bastard” the moment you met, or staring at his head. But for the Captain of the Guards, who’d already sensed danger, there was only one option left.

“I-I’m sorry.”

“Some stray mutt barges in out of nowhere, raising hell… At least you know when to back down.”

The captain felt wronged. He didn’t know who this middle-aged man was. He’d ridden hard since early morning to meet someone else.

How did things end up like this? Was the information wrong from the start?

Tang Sadok, Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, had approved the meeting. Yet the person the captain had come to see was nowhere in sight. Instead, a menacing bald man stood across from him, staring as if he meant to eat him alive.

That last part, however, was all in the captain’s head.

The middle-aged man—Jeok Cheongang—snorted. His gaze settled on the captain as he sank into thought.

Uninvited guests, barging in during broad daylight. Ordinarily, he’d have kicked them out on their asses. Officials were another matter, especially the Captain of the Guards, one of the City Lord’s closest men.

I can guess why they’re here.

Jeok Cheongang had eyes and ears. However little interest he took in the world around him, rumors still reached him. He’d heard that the City Lord had been confined to his sickbed for a couple of months.

“You came to see the Divine Physician?”

The captain, already on edge, stared at him. Two things startled him: the Divine Physician, whom even the imperial court had failed to find, really was staying with the Sichuan Tang Clan—and Jeok Cheongang had mentioned the renowned physician as casually as if he were Jang Sam from next door.

“I wasn’t sure whether to believe it. Is he really here?”

“What an ill-mannered bastard. Answer what I asked.”

“Y-yes.”

“Because the City Lord is ill?”

“Yes. I don’t know if you’ve already heard, but… We’re here to treat the City Lord’s illness.”

“Surely you have plenty of physicians.”

“That…”

The Captain of the Guards hesitated for a moment, but not for long.

He didn’t know who the man before him was, but he was clearly someone of considerable standing in Murim. He’d inserted himself into a meeting arranged by the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan as though it were nothing. However badly the clan had been struck, challenging the authority of Tang Sadok, the Myriad-Poison Asura, took more than nerve. It took madness.

And then Jeok Cheongang spoke one sentence, enough to make the Captain of the Guards the most honest man in the world.

“You don’t have to force yourself to talk. Once you’ve been beaten senseless, you’ll start remembering things you’d forgotten.”

“…!”

“I must be seeing things. Your mouth still looks shut.”

Deeply grateful that his subordinates weren’t here, the Captain of the Guards hurriedly opened his mouth.

“The City Lord’s condition is that serious.”

“Five.”

“Pardon?”

“That answer was worth five hits. I’ll take one off for every proper answer you give from now on.”

Is he insane?

Jeok Cheongang hadn’t so much as blinked while making the threat. The captain’s knees went weak. He’d been a master of some renown among wandering martial artists, yet he felt he wouldn’t stand a chance against this man, who looked about his age.

“Go on, then. Spit it out properly.”

Jeok Cheongang spread the fingers of one hand. The captain forced out his answer.

“It’s quite different from what people say. Even the renowned physicians nearby have given up.”

“So you need the Divine Physician?”

“Yes. After everything we’ve tried, there should have been at least some improvement. Instead, his condition keeps getting worse.”

“Then it must be a race against time.”

“It is. But…”

The captain licked his dry lips before continuing.

“The City Lord’s illness is a little—no, very strange.”

“Strange…”

Jeok Cheongang murmured and folded one finger.

“Four. Go on.”

“Sometimes he’s conscious and can move about, but at other times he thrashes around like someone who’s gone mad.”

“Rather than *like* a madman, hasn’t he simply gone mad?”

“I thought so at first. The unmistakable symptoms started right after he returned from the Imperial Capital.”

“The Imperial Capital?”

“Yes. He was summoned to court over the Blood Tragedy that happened four months ago.”

The Sichuan Blood Tragedy had caused an enormous upheaval, even to an outsider with no ties to Murim. The authorities and Murim might have kept out of each other's affairs, but an event of that scale was bound to have repercussions.

More than ten thousand martial artists had fought in Sichuan, territory of the Great Nation. Countless people died or were wounded, and smoke from the cremation of the dead lingered for more than three days.

"Word spread quickly. It happened not far from Chengdu, and there were too many witnesses for it not to. But the biggest problem was…"

Jeok Cheongang, who'd been listening quietly, tossed out a single word.

"Dark Heaven."

"Yes. The court learned that members of Dark Heaven had disguised themselves as government soldiers."

"The higher-ups must have been furious."

"I spent years in Murim myself, but authority and saving face matter everywhere, don't they?"

Whether a man made his living by the sword or by the pen, he was still human. And the dignity and authority of the unified dynasty—founded after an age of warring powers—were not to be challenged.

Dark Heaven had done just that. Disguised as government soldiers, they'd walked the streets in broad daylight and gone on to carry out a horrific massacre.

Which means…

Jeok Cheongang sorted through his tangled thoughts and spoke.

"This is more interesting than I expected. Fine. Three. Keep going."

"After returning from the Imperial Capital, the City Lord took to his bed. Strictly speaking, it began on his way back to Sichuan."

"The higher-ups must have given him a thorough dressing-down."

"The court's reprimand was part of it, but he also fell ill because he lost what he cherished most in the Imperial Capital."

"What he cherished most?"

"Yes."

The captain gave that brief answer, then fixed his gaze on Jeok Cheongang's three raised fingers.

"…You crafty bastard."

"The City Lord doesn't favor me for nothing."

"Fine. Two."

"Be a little more generous. One."

"Do you want to spend the rest of your life with one eye?"

"…"

"Fine. One."

The Captain of the Guards stared at the last finger still raised and swallowed hard before speaking.

“His favored concubine.”

“His favored concubine?”

“Yes. Her name was Aehyang. He couldn’t live without her.”

“If he took her all the way to the Imperial Capital in the middle of that mess, I get the idea. So what, did he lose her in the street?”

“No. To be precise, a high-ranking person in the Imperial Capital took her from him.”

“Important enough to take the City Lord’s concubine. Who?”

“Well…”

Jeok Cheongang folded his last finger at the captain’s hesitation. Then he heard the answer and his eyes widened.

“The Son of Heaven.[3299]”

[3299] “Son of Heaven” is a traditional Chinese imperial title associated with the Mandate of Heaven.

Chapter 847

The world was vast.

Yet just as the two characters for □□—“all under Heaven”—suggested, Heaven stood above it all.

The wide earth and the seas. The living and the dead.

Nothing could hide from Heaven.

Even birds flying with the clouds across the distant sky looked up to it. So did humans, who rose and fell without end and turned their blades on one another.

All wondered what magnificent being might dwell up there.

That was what Heaven meant to people.

An unknown realm they could only gaze at, never reach. Something they feared and revered in equal measure.

So perhaps it was only natural that the one who possessed all under Heaven came to be called the Son of Heaven.

The blue sky looking down on everything was the ultimate symbol of authority, after all.

But even the Son of Heaven is just a man. He steals another man’s favored concubine like anyone else.

Jeok Cheongang’s surprise vanished, replaced by a quiet laugh.

The Captain of the Guards looked uncomfortable at the sound. “It wasn’t exactly a funny story.”

“No? From where I’m sitting, it’s plenty funny. A man they call the Son of Heaven steals his subject’s favored concubine, and that subject gets so lovesick he’s at death’s door.”

“…!”

The Captain of the Guards was so shocked he forgot to breathe.

He’d already guessed the man was crazy, but to speak so disrespectfully of the Son of Heaven—

He hurriedly checked for anyone nearby, then managed to force the words out. “A-are you insane? I don’t know who you are, but how dare you say that about His Majesty the Emperor…!”

“What, are you scared?”

“Do you even have to ask? Good heavens, if anyone else had heard you, you’d be accused of treason on the spot.”

“Hm. Treason.”

Jeok Cheongang scratched his chin as he considered it.

Things might have been different in the past, but now he was a Master with a Disciple and a member of the Murim Alliance.

"That could be a little troublesome."

"A little troublesome? Do you think treason is some petty offense?"

"It's hardly grave enough to warrant exterminating a man's nine degrees of kin.[3300] The Son of Heaven is made of flesh and blood like anyone else. What does it matter if someone insults him?"

"…!"

"Look at your face. Heh heh."

The Captain of the Guards stood frozen with his mouth agape. Jeok Cheongang slapped his knee and laughed.

He had lived for a hundred and several dozen years. He'd seen the age of warring heroes, when the blood never dried, and the birth of a new unified dynasty with his own eyes.

Awe and reverence for the Son of Heaven?

What a joke.

For a very long time, the title had meant little to Jeok Cheongang.

Just someone a little more extraordinary than most, with far greater ambition and cruelty.

That had always been his assessment. After hearing what his one and only Disciple had to say, he was more certain of it than ever.

He'd been right.

The Son of Heaven isn't granted by Heaven; he is born amid bloodshed and countless corpses.

Jeok Cheongang suddenly remembered the stories Jin Taekyung had told him: astonishing tales of a giant iron bird taking to the sky and traveling among countless stars.

As he thought of them and watched the Captain of the Guards still standing frozen, he couldn't help letting out another laugh.

"I understand. There are mountains of things even this old man knows nothing about. How could a youngster like you begin to imagine them?"

"Th-this old man? A youngster?"

"The world is vast, and time keeps moving. Perhaps Dongfang Shuo, who lived three thousand *jiazi*, could watch it all change."[3301]

The Captain of the Guards stared at him blankly.

The man looked about his age, yet spoke like someone from another era. Worse, the captain couldn't make sense of a word he was saying.

"What on earth does that—"

[3300] The "nine degrees of kin" refers to an extended family circle that could be subjected to collective punishment for treason.

[3301] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

The Captain of the Guards trailed off.

“You needn’t try to understand. Anyone listening to that would have the same question.”

“…!”

The sudden voice at his ear made the captain gasp. Instinctively, he reached for the sword at his waist to draw and swing it.

Or tried to.

Until a terrifyingly immense energy erupted from somewhere and pressed down on his entire body.

Whoosh!

A wave of qi, hot as flames and heavy as a massive boulder.

The Captain of the Guards froze, not daring even to breathe.

His head had bowed beneath the force pressing down on it. His eyes trembled with agitation as he stared at his hand, still short of the sword hilt.

H-how?

Only the unanswered question drifted through the Captain of the Guards’ mind, bleached white with shock.

How could this be?

He’d left Murim for a comfortable life in government service, but he was still a Peak master.

Nor was he some hothouse flower raised in the shelter of a prestigious sect. He’d come up as a wandering martial artist, a Peak master hardened by real combat.

He’d spent more than twenty years as a wanderer. He’d gone to war when he was barely old enough to grow peach fuzz and survived like a stubborn weed.

He might not have learned the fine martial arts taught to the disciples of great sects, but he was proud that his experience on the brink of death more than made up for it.

And yet…

If I move, I die.

He could see it clearly. Feel it.

Death’s shadow had drawn close. Before him stood a wall he could never overcome, no matter how many times he was reborn.

Drip.

At that very moment, a bead of cold sweat that had formed without his noticing ran down from the Captain of the Guards’ chin.

“It’s a hot day. That’s a bit much to put a guest through.”

Ssshhh.

At the calm voice, the heat scattered as though it had never been there.

The Captain of the Guards let out the breath he'd been holding and took several ragged breaths. In his ears, the sound of a conversation reached him.

"A guest? He's some nobody here to make a request hardly worth calling one."

"He's my guest, to be precise. He came to see me."

"What kind of guest tries to draw a sword the moment he arrives?"

"I can understand it. He was already shaken, and then someone startled him."

"Quiet. You're only safe thanks to this old man."

"I wouldn't dare compare myself to you, Sir Jeok, but my Master did teach me a thing or two. You needn't worry."

"No, but this brat who doesn't even have the blood dried on his head has been talking back to me all this time—"

"As a physician, I should point out that if the blood in your head dries up, you die."

"You—!"

The Captain of the Guards, listening to them, lifted his head in confusion.

The man Jeok Cheongang had called a wet-behind-the-ears brat had snow-white hair. He looked at the captain with kind eyes.

"Are you all right?"

"…!"

In that instant, the Captain of the Guards recognized the old man by instinct.

The old man had the bearing of an immortal, and their conversation had supplied the rest.

"D-Divine Physician?"

The old man—the Divine Physician—smiled wryly and nodded.

"Yes. I arrived late and caused you trouble without meaning to."

"N-no! Not at all!"

The Captain of the Guards hurriedly waved his hands, then glanced nervously at Jeok Cheongang.

Meeting the Divine Physician at last was wonderful. But it was nothing beside the question of who that terrifying bald, middle-aged man might be.

Could it be…?

The scattered pieces in his mind seemed to fall into place all at once.

Jeok treated the Divine Physician, who looked well past seventy, like a child. Merely releasing his qi had been enough to bind the captain's entire body.

No—more precisely, it was Scorching Yang Qi.

And then there was what the Divine Physician had called him.

He said "Sir Jeok." He definitely did.

The Captain of the Guards swallowed hard.

It was absurd. A crazy thought.

But he couldn't help it. As far as he knew, there was only one person in all the world who fit all those details.

"Th-that man… Could he be F-F-Fire—"

The Captain of the Guards stammered, unable to finish. Jeok Cheongang frowned.

"That's right. I'm the Fire King. Not the F-F-Fire King."

"Eek!"

"…Why does that reaction rub me the wrong way? You'd think I was the Grim Reaper."

At Jeok Cheongang's baffled look, the Divine Physician remembered something his Master had once told him.

> "As a rule, it's best to keep your distance from martial artists."
>
> "Why?"
>
> "Of all the kinds of people in the world, they're the most vile, violent, and—on top of that—stupid."
>
> "Ah, I suppose that's true to some extent."
>
> "…What do you mean by that?"
>
> "Nothing. But I thought not all martial artists were like that."
>
> "True. But steer clear of those who follow the demonic, heterodox arts. Ninety-nine out of a hundred are idiots."
>
> "I've heard there are righteous heroes among the orthodox faction. Should I avoid them, too?"
>
> "If you can, yes. They talk about benevolence and righteousness, but half of them are idiots."
>
> "Then what about martial artists who belong to neither the orthodox faction nor the ranks of those who follow the demonic, heterodox arts?"
>
> "They're so unruly, and so many of them are unknown, that it's hard to judge. But based on my experience, you only need to remember two things."
>
> "What are they?"
>
> "The Fire King. The Fire Gate Clan. Repeat them and burn them into your mind."
>
> "The Fire King. The Fire Gate Clan."
>
> "Once isn't enough. This time, say them and engrave them on your heart."
>
> "The Fire King. The Fire Gate Clan."
>
> "Good. Remember those two."
>
> "I think I've heard the title Fire King before, but why do I need to remember it so well?"
>
> "Avoid him."

> “Pardon?”
>
> “Never meet him, no matter what. If you hear a rumor that the Fire King has appeared somewhere while I’m away, leave the entire province.”
>
> “What? What kind of person is he that I’d have to go that far?”
>
> “A lunatic.”
>
> “…?”
>
> “The Fire King—or rather, the Fire Gate Clan—are lunatics who’ve spent generations fighting orthodox martial artists and followers of the demonic, heterodox arts alike. They beat people when they’re in a bad mood, when they’re in a good mood, and some days when they’re neither happy nor upset.”
>
> “…How can people like that exist?”
>
> “They do. There’s a mad sect that’s spent more than three hundred years breeding—no, producing—one generation of insanely strong lunatics after another.”

The Divine Physician remembered that day clearly. His Master, renowned as the greatest assassin of all time and unfailingly composed, had used the word *mad* three times to impress the danger upon him.

Then why does Sir Jeok look so offended? It all sounds right to me.

He kept that thought to himself. Stopping Jeok Cheongang, who had seized the captain by the collar and begun shouting at him, came first.

“Do I look that vicious to you? Huh?”

“Eek! N-no!”

“Then why is your voice shaking? Are you mocking me for being bald?”

“Eek! I-I didn’t! Please spare me!”

“If your voice shakes one more time, every last hair on your body is going to…!”

“Sir Jeok, please. Calm down.”

The Divine Physician sighed as he stopped Jeok Cheongang, then spoke to the trembling Captain of the Guards.

“I happened to hear the gist of the situation. To get straight to the point, I can’t leave.”

“Y-yes? Why not?”

“From what you’ve told me, the City Lord is suffering from an unusual case of lovesickness. As a physician, I must tend to those who are sicker and in greater pain.”

“B-but he’s behaving nothing like himself!”

“That’s only natural. He’s had the person he loves taken from him. How could he not be suffering? If my patients improve later on, I’ll come by then, even if it’s only once…”

The Divine Physician trailed off and looked toward the slightly open door.

Hurried footsteps and ragged breathing drew closer, loud enough for everyone to hear. With them came the distinctive clank of armor, a sound seldom heard from a martial artist.

Tap-tap-tap! Clank!

Sure enough, a figure in gleaming armor soon ran up and stopped at the door, nearly collapsing.

“You…”

The Captain of the Guards’ eyes widened when he recognized a subordinate who should have been back at the City Lord’s residence. The man dragged in a ragged breath and cried out, “Th-the City Lord…!”

Chapter 848

Every now and then, I found myself wondering.

Just how often did I pass out? How many times had it happened?

If the System window summarized my life, how much of it would be time I'd lost while unconscious?

Damn it. I had no idea.

All that mattered right now was that I'd just woken up—and found myself face-to-face with an ugly bastard who looked like a monster.

"Whoa, shit! You scared me. Who are you?"

The monster answered in a mumble.

"It's me."

"Me who?"

An unusual name I'd never heard before, attached to a face I wouldn't want to see even in my dreams.

Baffled, I asked again.

"Are you from the Sichuan Tang Clan, by any chance?"

"…"

"Tang Me?"

"Captain, that joke's a bit much."

Captain. The word from the monster's mouth left my jaw hanging open.

There was only one person who called me that these days.

"Mujin? Hyuk Mujin?"

"Yes."

"Good heavens, what happened to your face?"

"Someone beat me up."

When you're busy, it's easy to forget the little things.

Only then did I remember beating Hyuk Mujin black and blue a few days ago. I smiled warmly.

"Ah, I almost didn't recognize you. You got so handsome."

"Should I thank you?"

"If you do, I'll gladly accept. But your face wasn't this fu—this handsome when I last saw you."

"Some lunatic tried to put me to sleep forever. I couldn't do a thing."

"A lunatic? Who?"

"Some guy whose only goal in life is to stuff himself until he bursts."

Of the people I knew, only two lunatics came to mind.

Cheongpung. And Taishan.

Of course, Cheongpung was probably traveling all over the land with the Slaughter Saint, searching for traces of Dark Heaven. There was no way he'd just pop up at the Sichuan Tang Clan.

That left one lunatic.

"Can you see my face right now? That lunatic Taishan hit me before the swelling had even gone down. It swelled up three times as much."

"I get it, you're three times more handsome. Now get your face out of mine. Or help me sit up."

"Sorry, but I can't. If I get any closer, I'll smell your breath too. It's hard enough standing here as it is."

"What?"

At first, I didn't understand what he meant.

Then the terrible stench hit my nose.

"Ugh."

I barely held back a gag and pushed myself upright.

As if he'd expected that, Hyuk Mujin nodded and handed me a waterskin and a scrap of cloth.

"It really stinks, doesn't it? Plug your nose with this, like I did, and rinse your mouth out. And try to cover your mouth when you talk…"

"If you don't want to get even more handsome, shut up. My stomach's already turning."

"Sorry. But your breath really is awful, Captain. What on earth did you eat?"

"Shit."

"Good heavens, why would you eat that?"

"…"

Was that idiot Hyuk Mujin actually taking me seriously? Or was he just trying to mess with me?

After a moment's thought, I let out a deep sigh. I stuffed the scrap of cloth he'd given me up my nostrils and rinsed my mouth out several times. Only then did it feel like I could breathe again.

Anyway, what exactly happened?

My last memory was Jeok Cheongang forcing me to swallow that awful pill.

No—to be precise, I'd felt heat seep into my body just before I lost consciousness.

It had been as familiar as coming home. Warm, rather than hot.

It was Old Master's Scorching Yang Qi. I'm sure of it.

Just as the world held more colors than the seven in a rainbow, qi came in more than one kind.

I didn’t know how many sects in the world used Scorching Yang Qi, but the Fire Gate Clan was its root. The qi I’d felt had unquestionably belonged to Jeok Cheongang.

Which means…

I slowly looked around.

The room was as clean and tidy as when I’d first arrived. But the stench lingering in the air and the dark marks on the floor were still there.

“It took ages to clean that up. It was sticky and smelled so bad I thought I was going to die.”

Hyuk Mujin had caught my gaze and was quick to complain.

“The Divine Physician said impurities came out of your body as a kind of mucus. Um, what did he call it? I knew the term, but it’s slipped my mind. Pushing… pushing…”

“Pushing the meridians and passing through the acupoints.”

At my offhand reply, Hyuk Mujin nodded.

“Oh, right. That thing I’d only ever heard about.”

No wonder he’d only heard of it. Pushing the meridians and passing through the acupoints required considerable preparation and sacrifice. It wasn’t something people attempted lightly.

Not even masters who’d reached Supreme Peak were exceptions.

It took a tremendous amount of mental strength, and the practitioner had to infuse part of their own internal energy evenly throughout the other person’s body.

And if it failed, the damage was severe.

But Jeok Cheongang had performed the treatment while I was unconscious, accepting the risk and the loss of internal energy.

It wasn’t the first time he’d treated me that way, but I couldn’t help feeling grateful —and guilty.

…He didn’t have to go this far.

If I’d been hovering between life and death, I might have asked him to. But until now, I’d been getting by well enough.

And we were in a situation where anything could happen at any moment. For everyone’s sake, it was better to preserve even a little more of the Fire King Jeok Cheongang’s strength than the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung’s.

Of course, if I said that in front of Old Master, he’d tear into me.

I let out a quiet laugh and drew up the Scorching Yang Qi. The increase in my internal energy wasn’t enough to show, but I could feel it at once.

Slowly. Carefully.

I sent the Scorching Yang Qi—now a little over three jiazi[3302]—flowing like lava through every limb and acupoint in my body. At the same time, I quietly examined everything deep within me.

My acupoints were wider and sturdier. My blood had cleared now that the impurities were gone, and my organs were working normally.

I drew in a long breath and sent the Scorching Yang Qi flowing faster.

It didn't take long for the slow-moving lava to become a blaze sweeping across a plain.

Sssshhhh.

Once around. Twice. Three times.

The circulation of qi that had begun as a Small Circulation became a Great Circulation. The fire dragon swept through hundreds of major and minor acupoints, putting my insides in order once more, then finally returned to my lower dantian and coiled up.

And just when everything seemed perfect—

Throb.

A sudden pain struck my lower dantian. I finished circulating my qi and clicked my tongue bitterly.

So this still isn't enough.

That horrible pill the Divine Physician had made and Jeok Cheongang's treatment must have been the best they could do for me right now.

But even with all their efforts, they hadn't been able to heal me completely.

The price of using power my body couldn't handle was bitter. Wishing otherwise wouldn't change the reality.

A vessel faced with more water than it could hold had only two choices.

It could hold what it was able to—or break under the weight of the water pouring in.

I was in the latter situation.

"…It's only a crack for now, though."

At my involuntary mutter, Hyuk Mujin, who'd been standing guard, asked, "Huh? What is?"

"You don't need to know. It's just something."

"Wow, that's cold. Where are you going to find a right-hand man as loyal as me?"

"As I've told you time and again, you're barely my pinky toe."

"Now that I think about it, that's not so bad."

"What?"

"Your pinky toe. It hurts the most when you stub it on a doorframe."

[3302] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Three jiazi are 180 years.

"…"

Was it just me, or was that guy becoming a formidable opponent?

Briefly at a loss for words, I shook my head.

"Cut the nonsense. Go fetch some water. I need to wash up. I feel disgusting."

"Now?"

"Yeah. I can't stand this smell."

I wrinkled my brow at the stench clinging to my clothes. Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head.

"Um, Captain. That might be a little difficult."

"What did you say?"

I blinked and asked in a serious voice, "Are you talking back to me? Is your face itching because you want to be the most handsome man of all time?"

"Please stop hitting me. I'm begging you."

"Then why are you talking nonsense?"

"I'm not talking back. I mean we don't have time. Everyone's ready and waiting for you to wake up."

"…Ready? Waiting for me to wake up?"

"Yes. We'll put up with the smell somehow, so let's just leave."

What the hell was he talking about?

As I stared at him, bewildered, Hyuk Mujin hurriedly rummaged through his robes and pulled out a sheet of yellow paper.

"What's that…?"

"It's a letter Sir Jeok and the Divine Physician left before they departed. They told us to get everything ready and bring you as soon as you woke up, without wasting any time."

Jeok Cheongang and the Divine Physician had left ahead of us. And they'd left a letter.

Trying to make sense of the questions that still wouldn't go away, I unfolded the rough-textured yellow paper. At that moment, a single line written in a strikingly vigorous hand—presumably the Divine Physician's—seared itself into my eyes.

> City Lord of Sichuan Province. Deceased.

"…!"

The Divine Physician suddenly remembered a lesson his Master had once taught him.

His Master had taken a fearsome number of lives, yet rescued countless others from the brink of death.

“What do you think is the most frightening illness in the world?”

“Cancer, I think.”

“Why do you think so?”

“Tumors too small to see with the naked eye grow deep inside the body. You’re fortunate if you notice the signs early, but without a physician of exceptional skill, people often die without ever receiving proper treatment.”

“You’re not wrong. But if you find the right physician in time, it can be cured without help from Heaven.”

“Isn’t that because you’re the Divine Physician, and a martial arts master who’s reached the stature of a grandmaster?”

“No. Any physician whose skill I would recognize could do it. You included.”

“You flatter me, Master. But I still don’t know what answer you’re looking for.”

“Flesh that’s been gouged or torn can be stitched together. Twisted or broken bones can be set. Even if an organ is injured, you can open the body and examine it.”

“Ah, I understand now.”

“What is it?”

“An illness of the mind.”

“That’s right. A sickness of the mind can’t be seen, stitched up, or set. It kills patients more stealthily than an assassin and more cruelly than a fiend.”

“Then how should we treat people like that?”

“First, meet them as one person to another, not as physician and patient. Second, listen without a word. Third, become their friend.”

“And if even that doesn’t help, and the patient chooses to die…”

“Carefully prepare their body for burial, and see them off on their final journey. But whoever the patient may be, always remember one thing.”

“What is it?”

“No one dies without a cause. Find the cause first.”

“…!”

The Divine Physician came back to himself and opened his eyes.

On the broad, lavish bed lay a corpse, as if in a deep sleep.

City Lord of Sichuan Province. Why did you die?

Was it grief over having his beloved concubine taken from him? Or anger at himself for being powerless to stop it?

Or perhaps…

Was it never lovesickness at all, but something else?

The Divine Physician gazed calmly down at the City Lord’s corpse.

A renowned physician from Sichuan had already concluded that the high-ranking man had died suddenly. But after examining the body for more than three shichen,[3303] the Divine Physician disagreed.

What grudge did you incur?

Puk.

He drew a long needle from an acupoint with a question the dead man would never hear. Then he studied the tiny thing writhing on its sharp tip and murmured,

"…Gu poison."[3304]

[3303] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen are approximately six hours.

[3304] *Gu* is a traditional Chinese term for poison or harmful magic associated with venomous creatures, often insects.

Chapter 849

One shichen.[3305]

That was how long it took us to reach the City Lord's Hall, which served as both his residence and his government offices.

Thudududud!

Stealing Ju Wongong's carriage—no, borrowing it—had been a stroke of genius.

The six-horse carriage was lavish enough to turn heads at a glance, and it had a kind of magic that made horrific traffic jams disappear.

"Stop! Stop! Halt at once!"

"State your identity and business… Wait, I've seen this carriage somewhere before."

We'd turned a crowded main road into an autobahn in the blink of an eye. Of course we stood out even from a distance.

The guards' eyes went wide when they saw the carriage hurtling toward them. Then someone shouted, giving them no time to do anything else.

"Open it!"

"Y-yes?"

"I said open the gate, you idiots!"

"Y-yes, sir! Open the gate!"

Rrrrmmmble!

Had someone given them orders beforehand?

We didn't stop the carriage or go through any of the checks we should have.

The enormous iron gates swung open to match the carriage's rapidly approaching speed. Hyuk Mujin, seated on the driver's bench, didn't ease up on the reins until we'd passed through no fewer than five gates.

Pffft. Pffft.

The six fine horses snorted after their nonstop gallop. As the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and I climbed down from the carriage, a group of strangers approached us.

"Young Hero Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon?"

The man at their head got straight to the question, as if he couldn't spare a moment.

But there was something subtly different about him from the usual government official. Even military officers in government service tended to avoid addressing someone directly by a Murim sobriquet.

A martial artist?

[3305] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

I studied the man, who wore lighter armor than the others. Song Ilseom's Sound Transmission reached my ear.

— I know him. He won't recognize me, though.

— You know him? Who is he?

— He was fairly well-known as a wandering martial artist. I heard he retired later on…but I didn't know he'd left Murim altogether to join the government.

— Really?

— Yes. My memory is accurate.

— Then why are you slipping into casual speech again? Are you older than me?

— I'm fairly sure I'm much older.

Oh, right.

I'd briefly forgotten that Song Ilseom was a few years older than me, even by modern standards.

But if I let that slide, discipline in the Fire Dragon Pavilion would fall apart. I put the full authority of the Pavilion Master into my Sound Transmission.

— So what if you're older? Want to end up like Hyuk Mujin?

— …

— If you don't like it, you can be Pavilion Master.

Song Ilseom gave me a cold, flat stare, then sighed and shook his head.

The former wandering martial artist spoke again, looking straight at me this time.

"Are you Young Hero Jin Taekyung?"

"That's me."

"Those who arrived before you told me to expect you. This way, please."

He briefly introduced himself as the Captain of the Guards for the City Lord of Sichuan Province, then led us deep into the City Lord's Hall.

"I presume you've already heard what happened."

I nodded as I walked behind him.

"To some extent."

"You must have been quite taken aback."

"At first, a little. I thought it was someone I knew."

"Ah, do you mean the Acting City Lord?"

"Yes."

There were currently two City Lords in this land.

No—there *had* been two.

Ju Wongong, a distant imperial relative with whom I'd had some history.

And the original City Lord of Sichuan Province, who'd been bedridden for the past few months.

What was the name of the guy who just died? Won Gyun?

A name like that was unusually memorable for an extra. He sounded like the sort of guy who'd be a complete disaster at sea, even if he did fine on land.[3306] Then again, maybe I remembered him because of that enormous belly. He'd looked twenty months pregnant, not merely about to give birth.

"I don't know if you remember, but I once saw you up close," the Captain said.

"You saw me?"

"It was just before the Sichuan Blood Tragedy. You came to see the City Lord with His Highness Prince Shangshan's token and asked for support."

"Oh. Right. So you were there, too?"

"Yes. As the Captain of the Guards, I was at the City Lord's side. I never imagined this would happen back then."

He answered with a bitter expression and kept walking.

As befitted a place that was both the City Lord's residence and his government offices, people in fine official robes were everywhere.

"The atmosphere isn't as tense as I expected," Ju Hwaran murmured behind me. "I thought there'd already been an uproar."

The Captain nodded. "Those who work here knew something of the City Lord's illness."

The calm atmosphere on the grounds suggested that his death hadn't come as a sudden shock.

But I didn't take the situation at face value. If it were as natural and ordinary as it seemed, Jeok Cheongang and the Divine Physician would have had no reason to come here.

Besides…

If they knew only part of it, there must be something that still hasn't gotten out.

Lost in thought, I kept walking. The farther we went, the fewer people we encountered. Even the guards who'd been everywhere before disappeared.

At last, the Captain stopped in front of a magnificent stone building, more like an estate than a pavilion.

"This is where the City Lord was staying. I'd like to escort you farther, but I have orders to follow."

"Orders?"

"From the Acting City Lord. He said only two people, including Young Hero Jin, are to be allowed inside."

Two people?

I could understand if it were just me, but I had no idea who the other person was supposed to be.

[3306] The line alludes to the historical Won Gyun, a Korean naval commander remembered for a disastrous defeat at sea.

I frowned. Then an unexpected name slipped from the Captain's lips.

"Is there someone among your companions named Namho?"

"Huh?"

"Mm?"

Everyone's eyes widened as we looked in the same direction.

The Captain spotted Taishan, who stood there looking blank, and nodded as though he'd figured it out.

"Ah, that must be Great Hero Nam. A tiger-like bearing, just as his name suggests…"

Thwack! Thwack!

Namho emerged from behind Taishan's huge frame, huffing as he hammered the giant's thigh with two fists that looked unusually tiny today.

"Move! I said get out of the way! You useless freeloader!"

"Heehee. Stop it, Namho. Taishan's ticklish. Heeheehee."

"Fucking hell…!"

If Taishan had been an actual rock, maybe. But what could an egg do against Mount Taishan?

Taishan giggled at the tickling. Namho was about to let loose a torrent of curses when he noticed the Captain watching him. Instead, he gave the man a hearty laugh.

"I'm Namho. The tiger from the south. Namho."

"…"

"What's with that look?"

"N-no, it's nothing."

"No, explain yourself."

The Captain looked Namho up and down as if he were staring at an ant from the south. Without saying anything more, he gestured to one of his subordinates.

Creeeak.

The doors swung open to either side with an irritating squeal, as if the new intruder wasn't welcome.

Namho came right up beside me as I headed inside and whispered, "What's with his reaction? Is a tiger that funny? Huh?"

"…"

Out of respect for my elders, I couldn't bring myself to tell him the truth.

Maybe it was because of the City Lord's lofty station, or maybe because the dead man had been corrupt. Whatever the reason, the inside of the pavilion was spacious and lavish.

Step. Step.

Our footsteps echoed along the corridor paved with expensive bluestone.

A dozen or so men and women approaching from the other end bowed to Namho and me, then passed by.

"Physicians and female physicians. Looks like they came to examine the body."

Namho sounded calm again, as though nothing had happened. From the moment we entered the pavilion, he'd been taking in everything around him.

"Heh. They even embedded night-shining pearls in the ceiling. I can only imagine how much they squeezed the people dry."

"I don't know much about it, but even when I was in Sichuan, people didn't have much good to say about the dead City Lord."

"If the bastard who used those expensive pearls was the one who just died, good riddance."

"Maybe he bought them with his own money."

"What does that mean?"

"He paid for them himself."

Namho snorted. "Sometimes, you really are a sheltered young master who knows nothing about the world. Let this old man teach you something. Those with money and power always…"

"Use other people's wealth to fill their own bellies instead of spending what they have."

"Huh? You know? Is that how it is in Shanxi Province, too?"

"Not always, but…it's the same everywhere people live."

Namho furrowed his brow at my answer.

"That's odd."

"What is?"

"Well, you said it yourself—it's not something you experienced in Shanxi Province. You sound like someone whose hometown is somewhere else."

The sharp instincts of a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent.

Whenever Namho let this side of himself show, I could tell how much experience he had.

But he'll never guess the truth.

Martial arts skill wasn't the only thing I'd gained from everything I'd been through. I smiled as if his observation meant nothing.

"Do you have to taste shit to tell it from black bean sauce?"

"Someone around twenty would do exactly that. It's a phase everyone goes through."

"Everyone does, but not everyone earns the sobriquet Blazing Flame Divine Dragon around that age. Ah, this way."

I answered without missing a beat and turned down another corridor.

Namho looked at me with narrowed eyes for a moment, but then followed without another word. Meanwhile, I kept an ear out for the voices slowly drawing nearer.

"So, according to the Divine Physician's examination, it was a natural death?"

"It would be more accurate to say he died suddenly from emotional distress. His rapid weight loss was also one of the main causes."

"I see. That's why I kept telling him to lose some weight."

"…In any case, I agree with the other physicians' diagnoses. There's nothing particularly suspicious about the City Lord's—or rather, the former City Lord's—death."

"Ah, thank you. That Captain of the Guards has been making such a fuss that even I, this Young Master, was getting a little flustered. Now that the renowned Divine Physician of the realm has stepped in, it feels like I've gained a thousand troops."

"You flatter me. I've only done my duty as a physician."

"Come now, there's such a thing as too much modesty. Since you've handled this so well, I, this Young Master—or rather, this City Lord—will reward you handsomely. Someone, come here!"

I rounded the bend in the corridor and answered.

"I'm here."

"Summon the treasurer at once and have him give the Divine Physician wealth and grain…"

His voice trailed off.

Ju Wongong stared at me, his face darkening rapidly. After a long silence, he spoke.

"When…did you arrive?"

"Just now. Got anything left to do?"

"…A little."

"Then go. I have something to talk about."

"…But I do have something left to do."

"Put it off. You're obviously just going to spout nonsense."

At my firm reply, Ju Wongong lowered his head sadly. Jeok Cheongang watched him walk away, his back limp, then spoke in a serious voice.

"If you'd arrived fifteen minutes later, I might have had the rare experience of tearing open an imperial family member's mouth for the first time in my life."

"I'm only going to say this once: please don't ever do that."

"This old man isn't *that* crazy."

"…"

The problem was, he seemed exactly that crazy.

I let out a long sigh and turned to the Divine Physician, pretending not to hear Jeok Cheongang ask how I was feeling.

"So what is it, exactly?"

"What do you mean?"

"You wouldn't have told that idiot everything, would you? And seeing both of you here tells me enough."

The Divine Physician smiled ruefully at my flat reply.

"As expected of Sir Jeok's Disciple."

What was that supposed to mean?

I was still deciding whether to feel pleased or offended when the Divine Physician drew something from his sleeve. Namho's eyes widened.

"That's…"

"What is it?"

"Gu poison. A very rare kind found deep in Nanman. It's called Blood Soul Gu."

Jeok Cheongang nodded as he looked at it.

"Bringing that fellow here was worthwhile."

Chapter 850

Blood Soul Gu.

Namho had identified the gu poison for us, and the name alone sounded ominous.

Then again, I'd never seen a gu poison with my own eyes before.

I studied the tiny creature writhing on the Divine Physician's gloved palm.

It was much smaller than a grain of millet, with a thread-thin body the color of blood. It looked too small for an ordinary person to make out with the naked eye, yet it kept struggling to burrow into his skin.

As though that were its sole reason for existing.

"If I hadn't been careful from the start, it would have gotten me. It's incredibly strong for something so small."

Sssk. Ssssk!

As if it understood him, Blood Soul Gu thrashed harder, trying to escape. The Divine Physician carefully enclosed it in his hand, slipped it into a tiny gourd, and sealed the stopper tight.

Only after checking for gaps several times did he take off his thick leather gloves.

"Blood Soul Gu… My Master taught me countless things over the years, but honestly, I've never encountered a gu poison like this."

Namho nodded.

"That's only natural. Blood Soul Gu is scarcely known even in Nanman. More precisely, there can't be many people left who still remember the name."

"You mean…"

"This was a very long time ago. Nanman was divided into three powers, like a three-legged cauldron, and they were locked in a terrible war. That was when Blood Soul Gu first came to light."

I knew the story. I'd heard it several times during my stay in Nanman, and if you went back far enough, it involved my own sect, the Fire Gate Clan.

It had been passed down like a legend, by word of mouth and through the few records that remained. And one sect always stood at its center.

"…The Five Poisons Sect."

The name came out like a groan. I looked at Namho.

"Are you saying Blood Soul Gu came from the Five Poisons Sect?"

"It was so long ago that I can't say for certain. But if everything I saw and heard in Nanman is true, Blood Soul Gu was one of the venomous creatures the Five Poisons Sect created after countless attempts."

"But I never saw anything like it in the Poisonblood Grounds."

“Gu poisons favor deep, hidden places. Even after combing through the Poisonblood Grounds like you were stirring up a hornet’s nest, would you expect to spot something like that?”

He had a point.

The Poisonblood Grounds had crawled with bizarre monsters, including the Thousand-Year Spider. In all that chaos, I couldn’t have kept track of every creature—especially one as hard to see as Blood Soul Gu.

“I’ve heard of the Five Poisons Sect, too. One of our sect’s Four Founders left a brief account of Nanman.”

Jeok Cheongang had spoken up without warning. His somber gaze rested on the gourd holding Blood Soul Gu.

“But that thing is nothing like an ordinary gu poison. It’s hardy enough to survive having its body pierced by a large needle, yet it doesn’t carry enough deadly poison to kill its host outright.”

“That only makes it more likely to be Blood Soul Gu. Senior Jeok, the gu poisons you’re thinking of cause no trouble as long as the host takes the antidote at regular intervals.”

“That’s what everyone knows.”

“But Blood Soul Gu is different. Ordinary gu poisons are used to threaten and control their hosts. The Five Poisons Sect created that dreadful creature for one purpose alone.”

Everyone looked at Namho. He let out the breath he’d been holding.

“To kill its host. In a way, it’s a near-perfect means of assassination.”

“…!”

“I spent a long time in Nanman collecting information. I searched through every scrap of what little remained in the records and sought out the oldest and wisest people from each tribe. I had to feel my way toward the truth in their stories, then sift out whatever might be false.”

One day, after the Great Faction War had ended, the Martial God vanished without a trace.

Hundreds, even thousands, of sects bound together by every kind of interest and emotion had lost their focal point. Perhaps it was only natural that they began to collapse.

The Murim Alliance dissolved.

But the roots of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion remained throughout the world. In crumbling old inns. Along crowded streets.

And in the remote reaches of Nanman, where venomous creatures and fierce beasts ran rampant.

Namho was one of its deepest, oldest roots.

“The war between the Five Poisons Sect and the Nanman Beast Palace was fierce. Sometimes they were evenly matched; at other times, one side had the advantage.”

The war had lasted a hundred years, he said. Poison was poured into wells and rivers. The Nanman Beast Palace’s warriors and beasts cut down and tore apart the Five Poisons Sect’s Poison Men.

“All of Nanman was engulfed in poison and flames. Had it gone on, there would have been neither victor nor vanquished. Both sides would have perished.”

Namho looked from Jeok Cheongang to me.

“Until an outsider appeared.”

The leader of the Fire Gate Clan, who was traveling the world at the time, received a grand welcome the moment he arrived in Nanman.

A hundred Five Poisons Sect warriors greeted the stranger who dared enter their territory with poison and hidden weapons. The stranger promptly burned everything to the ground and joined forces with the Nanman Beast Palace.

“With the Fire Gate Sect Leader’s arrival, the tide turned sharply. The Five Poisons Sect must have realized they had nowhere left to retreat. As time passed, they began unleashing things more and more dreadful and vicious.”

When people have almost nothing left to lose, all that remains is spite.

The Five Poisons Sect prepared its final counterattack deep in Ailao Mountain, in its most secret and dangerous place: the Poisonblood Grounds.

“Near the end of the war, the Nanman Beast Palace’s finest warriors began dying one by one. Neither physicians versed in poisons and medicines nor spiritually gifted priests could tell why.”

The Divine Physician, who’d been listening to Namho in silence, spoke with a grim expression.

“They wouldn’t have had any visible injuries.”

“That’s right. It wasn’t poisoning or a plague. By the time the Nanman Beast Palace learned the cause, more than a hundred warriors had died.”

“Blood Soul Gu may move stealthily and be hard to see, but with so many victims, surely they could have found it sooner.”

“I thought so too. But there was a reason they didn’t.”

Namho shook his head slightly.

“Everyone was exhausted by a war that had lasted a hundred years. Peace had long since become a faded word, and death was seen as rest. In those circumstances, it must have seemed only natural for some warriors to succumb to madness.”

“Madness…?”

“That’s right. They said most of them would act like they’d lost their minds one day, then fight more bravely than anyone the next.”

The Divine Physician let out a faint sigh.

“The City Lord. Those were his symptoms. When I first heard about them, I thought he was suffering from an illness of the mind after losing his beloved concubine.”

“Blood Soul Gu grows stronger in a host whose mental strength has weakened. The two may well be connected.”

“Then how did the Nanman Beast Palace learn what was happening?”

“They said the information came from interrogating an Elder of the Five Poisons Sect after capturing him. At first, it wandered through the duodenum and the acupoints, using mild poison to cause auditory and visual hallucinations. In the end, it gradually ate away at the brain and drove its host to death.”

“…!”

“The warriors didn’t all die at the same time. Some lasted only six months; others held out for years.”

“So it only begins to act once its host is weak in body and mind.”

“That’s right. But its killing power fell far short of what the Five Poisons Sect had wanted, and it took far too long. Perhaps that’s why they managed to improve so few specimens before the sect was destroyed. That’s everything I found out.”

A heavy silence followed Namho’s last words.

No one spoke, but it wasn’t hard to guess what the others were thinking.

A great war that had drenched Nanman in blood for more than a hundred years.

And now, long after that war, Blood Soul Gu had appeared again—in a Great Nation official who wasn’t even a martial artist.

I closed my eyes. Two characters had been circling in my mind ever since I learned Blood Soul Gu came from Nanman. Instead of keeping them to myself, I said them aloud.

“Dark Heaven.”

The darkness before my eyes cleared. When I opened them, three faces looked back at me beneath the soft light of the night-shining pearls.

“Blood Soul Gu was almost forgotten even in Nanman. There’s only one way it could have reached the Central Plains. Dark Heaven brought it here.”

Jeok Cheongang spoke in a low voice.

“The Southern Heaven Demon Empress.”

“Dark Heaven has been in Nanman for decades, waiting for its moment in the Poisonblood Grounds. That was more than enough time to find Blood Soul Gu.”

“Enough time? They had time to spare.”

Jeok Cheongang gave a small nod, then asked, “But why would they harm this man?”

“That…”

My voice trailed off as I looked down at the City Lord of Sichuan Province's corpse.

His arms and legs had gone cold. His face was white as paper, without a trace of pain.

Jeok Cheongang had put his finger on the question.

Why kill this man? And why do it so secretly?

He had held the high office of City Lord, but that was all. He was a moderately greedy, corrupt official of the sort you could find anywhere.

If Dark Heaven wanted him dead, they could take his life as easily as pulling a coin from a pocket.

So why go to all this trouble?

Was it because he had sent government troops to help us during the Sichuan Blood Tragedy?

The thought crossed my mind, but I shook my head.

No. If it was retaliation, a far more horrific death would have served them a hundred times better. They could have shown the whole world what happened to anyone who opposed Dark Heaven—even a high-ranking official. Then even those who thought Murim had nothing to do with them would have been too afraid to defy it again.

But if they chose this method anyway…

There was something else. Some goal Dark Heaven wanted to achieve that we hadn't discovered yet.

And just as my thoughts led me there—

Step.

A faint footstep broke my concentration. I turned toward it on instinct and saw a small maid standing there, fear on her face.

"Um, well…"

Her hands were clasped tightly together. She looked at us anxiously and spoke in a voice barely louder than a whisper.

"I-I'm sorry, but the new City Lord asked me to find out when you'd be finished talking…"

Damn it. How had something so trivial broken my concentration?

I frowned without meaning to. Then a flash of insight shot through my mind.

The new City Lord. Ju Wongong. One of the few remaining members of the imperial family.

And the reason Dark Heaven had needed to dispose of the City Lord of Sichuan so secretly. No—not the reason. A suspicion.

If I was right, this was only the beginning.

The City Lord's death was the first sign of Dark Heaven's scheme, and it gave me reason to suspect they had one target in mind.

The Great Nation.

A chill ran up my spine.

Eyes wide, I watched the maid hurry away and managed to force out the words.

“We need to send people out. Now. Find out everything about the City Lord of Sichuan and Ju Wongong. No—the Emperor and all his relatives, too.”

At the same moment, a name surfaced in my memory.

Someone closer to the title of Son of Heaven than Ju Wongong, a distant member of the imperial family—or anyone else of imperial blood still alive.

Someone who might be the most important key of all.

“…Zhu Bao.”

“What?”

“Prince Shangshan. Zhu Bao.”

Inside my firmly shut Inventory, the token that little boy had given me seemed to tremble.

Chapter 851

It was an especially beautiful day.

Warm sunshine, a cool breeze, and wisps of pure white cloud.

The people working up a sweat wore smiles, and the well-kept main road bustled with crowds.

Perhaps that was why someone who always seemed pressed for time suddenly spoke to his coachman just as the man was about to set off in a hurry.

“Could we take it a little slower today? There’s no particular rush.”

“Pardon?”

“I’d like to take my time on the way back. Look around outside, too.”

The coachman wondered at his employer’s uncharacteristic mood, but put the question aside and eased the reins.

All he had to do was follow orders, after all. And he much preferred guiding the horses slowly and safely to shouting at people to get out of the way.

Still, he’s acting strange today. Did something happen inside?

The coachman glanced sideways. A sturdy wall, built up in two and three layers like a fortress, filled his view.

At their usual pace, it was one thing. At this rate, it would take a full fifteen minutes to reach the end of that wall.

Good grief. It’s impressive no matter how many times I see it.

The enormous estate stood not on the outskirts, but right in the heart of the city. The land was as valuable as it came.

Owning so much of it was proof enough of the family’s tremendous power, but that wasn’t what amazed the coachman most.

It was nothing like this when I first saw it.

A fallen great family.

There had been no better way to describe it. That was the cold reality, as the coachman and everyone else nearby had seen it.

Yet no one could have guessed that a family slowly declining, its past glory behind it, would rise in barely more than two years to rule an entire city.

Just goes to show, you never know what’ll happen.

The coachman looked up at the flag flying high above the stone wall. A breeze caught the silk, and four characters written in a bold, flowing hand caught his eye.

Jin Family of Taiyuan.

The owners of that enormous estate had become a symbol of Shanxi Province.

The changes to the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been swift and unmistakable. The pavilions and walls, shabby and crumbling when the coachman first saw them, had been repaired until they looked as solid as a fortress. Supplied with fine

weapons and elixirs, the family's martial artists now had a righteous light in their eyes that hadn't been there before.

And that wasn't all.

The entrance, once crowded with debt collectors demanding payment for the reckless Third Young Master's unpaid bills, was now so packed you could hardly set foot there—but for entirely different reasons.

Merchants from other regions came to entrust their business to the Jin Family Escort Bureau. At the end of each month, shopkeepers of every kind lined up to pay tribute, along with the martial arts sects and Branch Leaders under the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

So many of Shanxi Province's most important people came and went that they nearly wore out the threshold. Some people with nothing better to do even loitered nearby, spreading whatever they'd seen and heard.

Just like the two men squatting beside the roadside wall now.

"Didn't she come today, either?"

"Didn't who come?"

"Oh, come on. You know perfectly well who I'm waiting for. Why do you keep asking?"

"Don't tell me you're at it again…"

"What do you mean, 'again'? I've been devoted to her from the start."

"Cut the nonsense. If your wife catches you, she'll beat you to death—and I'll get killed, too."

"It's fine. You only die once, don't you?"

"I'm telling you, it's not fine. Your wife's arm is thicker than my calf."

"Good grief. You call yourself a man, getting scared like that? Just answer my question. Didn't she come today, either?"

"She was here just four days ago. Of course she didn't come today. Do you think she's an unemployed layabout like us, with nothing but time on her hands?"

"Damn it. I thought maybe this time I'd get to see her up close."

"Just give it up already. What would you do if you saw her up close?"

"Do I need another reason to see Shanxi's foremost beauty? I saw her from far away once, half a year ago, and my blurry old eyes cleared right up."

"Have you considered that one good whack from your wife might make everything go dark? And calling her Shanxi's foremost beauty hardly does her justice. She leads the Mount Heng Sword Sect despite being a woman—and she's formidable. If you cross her the wrong way, you won't walk away in one piece."

The man gazed dreamily into space, then swallowed.

"…Well, I heard she's got some old man following her around like a shadow, and he's got one hell of a temper."

“If temper were all he had, would they have called him the Tiger of Mount Heng? Quit acting up and go home while both your legs still work. Take care of your kid.”

“Take care of him? He’s all grown up.”

“Already? Time flies. I remember him being born just about this time last year.”

“Yeah. That’s right.”

“…Are you insane?”

The two men’s voices gradually faded.

Listening from his seat, the coachman gave a quiet laugh and gathered up the reins he’d let slacken for a moment.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

Drawn by four fine horses, the carriage made its slow way down the main road, just as his employer had asked.

In the past, a single four-horse carriage would have taken up half the street. But now the road was several times wider, and the crowds packed into it simply moved aside a little and carried on talking.

Most of what they said was idle chatter, but some of it was worth the coachman’s attention.

“Have you heard? The Jin Family of Taiyuan’s blacksmith shop has been making nothing but weapons lately.”

“I thought you were about to say something important. That’s been going on for a while, hasn’t it? The Jin Family of Taiyuan is a Murim sect. It’s hardly strange.”

“True. But for the past six months, they’ve dealt exclusively in weapons. If you want farming tools, you’ll have to go at least as far as Gohyeon.”

“Well, now. Gohyeon’s a good three or four days on foot. Luckily, the tools we bought earlier are so sturdy we won’t need more.”

“That’s because the craftsmen Old Man Jang brought with him know their trade.”

“Hey, don’t call him Old Man Jang. The Jin Family of Taiyuan trusts him with important work. You ought to call him Elder Jang Taebo now.”

“Ah, it’s a habit. Anyway, the more I think about it, the more worried I get. They say things in the martial world are tense these days. Do you think something big is about to happen…?”

“Put your worries aside and finish your game of Go.[3307] Dark Heaven or whatever can make all the trouble it wants; in the end, it’s a Murim affair. We have the Great Nation farther afield and the Jin Family of Taiyuan standing firm right here. What’s there to worry about?”

“I only brought it up because the rumors coming from all over don’t sound good. And things up on the northern plateau have changed after being quiet for the past year or two. Something isn’t right in the martial world.”

[3307] Go, called *baduk* in Korean, is a strategy board game in which players place stones to claim territory.

"What's going on up north now? I thought the Jin Family of Taiyuan had wiped out the mounted bandits."

"Do mounted bandits disappear just because you uproot them once? They're like weeds. They keep coming back. And a few merchant caravans that headed north last month…"

Even with his employer's instructions, there was only so long the coachman could keep the horses moving slowly.

Come on, get to the point.

He was still trying to catch the rest of the story as the carriage left the main road when his employer, who had spent the ride silently watching the scenery, suddenly spoke.

"Everyone has a lot to worry about. Then again, it's happening around them. How could they not notice?"

"Y-yes?"

"I mean those people. You've had your ears pricked up this whole time. Why are you so surprised?"

"Uh, well. It's just…"

The coachman swallowed and stammered on.

"You've never spoken to me first while we were traveling, so it caught me off guard."

"Ah. Well, I suppose it would."

The coachman glanced over his shoulder. Through the pearl-bead curtain, he caught a glimpse of his employer nodding as though it were nothing.

He also glimpsed skin powdered white and lips red as cherries.

He's definitely acting differently today.

What had gotten into him?

The coachman had served him for nearly a year, but his employer remained a mystery. He was always smiling, yet somehow it never seemed genuine. And there was only one occasion when he ever spoke to the coachman first.

When they reached their destination.

A brief "Thank you for your hard work" was both the beginning and the end of their conversations.

But today he spoke first, and he hasn't even looked at his bamboo slips on the road.

His high-ranking employer was always busy. He had a mountain of work to handle and people to meet everywhere.

After nearly a year of seeing him like that, perhaps it was only natural that today's change felt so strange. Perhaps that was why the coachman let a pointless curiosity he would normally have kept to himself slip out.

"Um, has something happened?"

“Hm?”

“Ah, well…”

The coachman regretted the question the moment he asked it. Nothing good could come of upsetting his employer, especially one so high-ranking.

But his employer was more forgiving than he’d expected.

“Hm. Something happened? Yes, I suppose it did. I heard some bad news not long ago.”

“I-I’m sorry.”

“No, why apologize over that? When you bow and scrape too much, it makes me uncomfortable, too. Brings back old memories.”

“Pardon?”

“Memories I never want to go back to. For example…”

His employer trailed off and gazed out the window.

Beyond the wooden lattice, children were laughing in a clean, orderly street.

“Going three whole days without food, then standing in the street singing to please people dressed in silk. Memories like that.”

“…!”

“Oh, don’t get the wrong idea. I’m not saying it to make you feel bad. It’s just something that happened.”

The coachman’s mouth fell open at the thought that someone of such high standing had lived through that. His employer watched the people passing slowly by and smiled faintly.

“It’s nice to see everyone looking so happy.”

It had happened a very long time ago.

But in someone’s memory, it remained a brand that would never fade.

Poverty. Death. Sorrow. Anger.

The days he had spent doing everything he could to escape the shackles that had gripped his throat since birth flashed past.

“I managed it somehow back then…but can I do it this time, too?”

The quiet mutter scattered on the wind.

The coachman didn’t dare say another word. He kept guiding the horses while his employer took in everything passing slowly around him.

As they drew nearer to their destination, hoofprints in the dirt came into clearer view. At last, his employer knew the time had come.

“Could I ask you a favor?”

“A favor…sir?”

His employer nodded at the coachman’s question.

“Yes, a favor. Consider it an apology, too, for not being very warm toward you until now.”

“Th-there’s no need to say that, sir. If you need anything, please give me an order, Deputy Military Commissioner.”

His employer—or rather, Hong Jin, Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province—parted his red lips.

“I’ll get off here. Go to Honghwaru right away and tell them. Or should I say the Lower District Sect’s Shanxi branch?”

“…!”

“You thought I wouldn’t know, didn’t you? But they’ve probably figured it out to some extent already. No matter how secretly the Embroidered Uniform Guard operates, they can’t avoid that many eyes.”

The fact that Hong Jin knew his identity, and the existence of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, said to act only on the Emperor’s orders.

The coachman couldn’t decide which shocked him more. Then he realized what he needed to ask.

“What would you have me do, Deputy Military Commissioner?”

“Tell them everything that’s happening. Then have them use every bit of the Lower District Sect’s information network to find one person.”

“One person?”

“Someone who can protect us in any situation—or rather, His Highness Prince Shangshan. The most trustworthy person in all Murim.”

Hong Jin spoke slowly, emphasizing every word.

“The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.”

“…!”

“Go. Hurry.”

That was all.

The carriage sped away like the wind. Hong Jin watched it until it vanished, then turned.

A group of riders descended on him amid the thunder of hooves.

“By imperial decree, you must come with us, Deputy Military Commissioner.”

“And His Highness Prince Shangshan?”

“Rest assured. He is unharmed—for now.”

“For now… All right, then.”

Hong Jin smiled.

Then he walked toward his young lord.

Chapter 852

The ways a Murim martial artist could get information were extremely limited.

The easiest places to start were inns and pleasure houses.

They were full of people from every walk of life. Listen for a while and you could hear all kinds of stories.

The downside was that none of the important information was there. Most of it was unverified rumor.

So martial artists whose heads weren't just for decoration, and who'd spent some time earning their keep with a sword, went to information merchants instead.

These professionals bought and sold information in every region. Their prices were steep, but their information was reliable.

The problem was that there were clear limits to what they could gather.

They could provide high-quality information about the region where they were based, but that was as far as it went.

For people with money, a respectable sect behind them, and a few useful connections, that left two natural choices.

The Lower District Sect.

And the Beggars' Sect.

They had taken root throughout the land. The weeds of this world had gathered one by one and grown a vast forest of their own.

The Beggars' Sect was one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, so its importance went without saying. But the Lower District Sect couldn't be dismissed, either.

Waiters and courtesans, coachmen and pickpockets. Back-alley gamblers and merchants running shops of every size.

Like the beggars of the Beggars' Sect, they were everywhere.

Their vast networks let them cast a net across the land and haul in a wealth of information. Even the Sect Leaders of the most prestigious Murim sects couldn't treat them carelessly.

Of course, there were exceptions to every rule.

"Gather everyone."

"Pardon?"

"Gather everyone. You have half a day. At the Sichuan Tang Clan."

At least for today, Jeok Cheongang was a Grand Mage.

In precisely half a day, he'd summoned the Lower District Sect and the Beggars' Sect, along with the Qingcheng and Emei Sects, and seated them all in one place.

"Um, may I ask why you've called us here so suddenly…?"

"Plant yourself quietly in a corner. You need to hear this, too."

Of course, Tang Sadok, the Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, was there as well.

But what surprised everyone except Jeok Cheongang was that the Sect Leaders of Qingcheng and Emei had come in person.

“I, Bicheonja of the Qingcheng Sect, a junior of the Murim, pay my respects to you, Senior.”

Sect Leader of the Qingcheng Sect or not, in front of Jeok Cheongang, he was a junior of the Murim.

Bicheonja looked as though he’d run hard enough to sweat through his soles. Jeok Cheongang nodded at his cupped-fist greeting. Bicheonja—or Cheongpung the Ancient Sword, as he was better known in Murim.

“So, is your master still doing well these days?”

“…He passed away twenty years ago.”

After a brief silence, Jeok Cheongang spoke without batting an eye.

“I was asking whether you’ve been tending his grave. No matter how busy you are, visit often and pull the weeds.”

“…Yes. I’ll remember that.”

Anyone could see Jeok Cheongang had forgotten, but Cheongpung the Ancient Sword showed the patience of a Daoist and took his seat.

No, it was probably more accurate to say he let it slide because this was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

No one in Murim could match Jeok Cheongang’s seniority, and his age and martial arts were overwhelming.

But Extinction Divine Nun, who’d taken the vacant post of Emei Sect Leader after the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, was someone even Jeok Cheongang couldn’t treat carelessly, given her age.

“You’re here, old hag.”

“…”

“…”

I take it back. I must’ve been mistaken.

He’s treating her however the fuck he wants. Seriously.

I pressed a hand to my forehead. Everyone else’s mouths fell open.

At least there was one saving grace: Extinction Divine Nun, famous for rampaging like a madwoman on the battlefield, was usually an exceptionally gentle person.

“Benefactor Jeok, you’re the same whenever I see you. In more ways than one.”

“Old hag, you’ve gotten older since I last saw you. It feels like forty years, not four months. I mean that literally.”

[3308] Amitabha is a Buddha whose name is invoked in East Asian Buddhist practice.

"Amitabha[3308]. At your age, you should've grown up long ago. When are you going to start acting your age?"

"I've grown about a hundred years younger, so I plan to live like this for another hundred. Though by then, Venerable Nun, you'll no longer be of this world."

"…Amitabha[3309]. That was too harsh."

"If you're that offended, you should Return to Youth yourself."

"Amitabhaaaaa[3310]!"

I sensed we were in deep shit and hurriedly stepped between them. It was the best move I could've made.

If they'd traded one more line, Extinction Divine Nun's wooden prayer block would've come down on Jeok Cheongang's skull.

Of course, Jeok Cheongang wouldn't have just let her hit him. The important thing was that Extinction Divine Nun's anger quickly subsided when I appeared.

"Oh, Benefactor Jin."

"Have you been well, Venerable Nun? No—I mean, Sect Leader."

"You needn't be so formal. Call me whatever feels comfortable. In any case, you've become even more striking since I last saw you. And such a full head of hair."

Extinction Divine Nun added that last part while looking at Jeok Cheongang, then patted my shoulder with her deeply wrinkled hand.

Perhaps because she thought so highly of the way I'd rushed around trying to minimize the damage during the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, both she and Cheongpung the Ancient Sword looked at me so fondly their eyes might as well have been dripping honey.

"Before we begin, I must say you've been through a great deal. I hear you distinguished yourself against Dark Heaven's fiends in Nanman and even brought the Nanman Beast Palace into the alliance?"

"Fellow Daoist Jin's chivalrous spirit is truly remarkable. I, too, can't help but admire you."

Words could travel a thousand li[3311] without legs.

The story had already begun making the rounds among people with decent information networks. And that certainly included everyone gathered here.

Two Sect Leaders from the Nine Sects and One Gang, not to mention leaders of the land's foremost information organizations.

"Congratulations, though belated, Great Hero Jin Taekyung. Our Shaanxi Branch Leader was delighted when she heard the news."

"I only wish that brat Gung Gibang—or rather, the Successor Beggar—could measure up to you even halfway. Anyway, what you did was incredible."

[3309] Amitabha is a Buddha whose name is invoked in East Asian Buddhist practice.

[3310] Amitabha is a Buddha whose name is invoked in East Asian Buddhist practice.

[3311] In this Chinese setting, one li is 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi).

The Lower District Sect's Sichuan Branch Leader politely offered his congratulations, mentioning Wolhwa, who was in Shaanxi. An Elder of the Beggars' Sect chuckled and jabbed me in the side, but at a single remark from Jeok Cheongang, his laughter stopped dead.

"Where's your Sect Leader? Why's some mere Elder hanging around?"

"…Sir Jeok, how could we bring the Sect Leader here from Henan in half a day?"

"Henan? That bastard's in Henan right now?"

"Yes."

Getting from Henan to Sichuan in half a day would've been impossible without a jet.

Jeok Cheongang seemed to accept that the Elder had a point and looked for another target.

"Hey. Lower District Sect."

"Yes, sir."

"Where's your Sect Leader?"

"I'd dearly love to bring him here, but even I don't know where he is. Our sect is organized into cells, so his location is a closely guarded secret…"

"So a nobody who doesn't even know where his own Sect Leader is showed up?"

For a Lower District Sect with countless members, a Branch Leader was on the same level as a Beggars' Sect Elder. The Sichuan Branch Leader swallowed hard under Jeok Cheongang's pressure.

"Of course not. Whatever information you want, we'll find it by any means necessary and bring it to you as quickly as we can!"

"Whatever you want. By any means necessary. As quickly as you can?"

"Yes, sir."

"That sounds good. I'll remember it clearly, so you remember this one thing, too. Understand?"

"I'm not sure what you mean…"

The Lower District Sect Branch Leader's eyes wavered. Then Jeok Cheongang's voice sounded, low and heavy.

"If even a single word of what's said here today gets out…"

Whoooosh.

He didn't finish the sentence, but he didn't need to.

The terrifying wave of qi that rolled out from Jeok Cheongang was a wordless warning against the slightest chance of a leak.

And there wasn't a single person here too slow to understand what he meant.

They understood, too, that something important was about to be discussed.

"Around noon today, the City Lord of Sichuan Province died."

With Jeok Cheongang's first words, the curtain rose. Every eye turned toward the Divine Physician and Namho as they stepped forward.

"The late City Lord died of illness. His physical and mental strength had declined sharply over the past few months, and that led to his death."

"The renowned physicians in the area have already examined the body at the City Lord's Residence and reached the same conclusion. The Divine Physician here has as well."

I added quietly, "A death by illness, beyond all suspicion. That's how it will be reported. Officially, at least."

I could feel the air around us shift.

Officially.

Anyone could hear the implication. That one word told them there was a secret the outside world didn't know.

At my quiet glance, the Divine Physician nodded, took a small wooden case from his robe, and carefully opened it.

"This is known as Blood Soul Gu."

The people who saw it stared wide-eyed. It was smaller than any insect I'd ever seen, and red as blood.

By the time everyone had left, evening had fallen.

Jeok Cheongang and I were the only ones left. We talked as we looked out at the pitch-black darkness that had settled all around us.

"How long do you think it'll take?"

"Who can say? All we can do now is trust them and wait."

"If we wait, we'll be too late. We need to move."

"One wrong turn, and it'll take even longer to find our way back. Besides, haven't we already learned something from their information?"

I nodded without a word.

Just as Jeok Cheongang said, we'd already received information from the Lower District Sect and the Beggars' Sect.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard.

No one living in this land could fail to know that name.

One of the Great Nation's most powerful and secretive forces, acting only on the orders of a single person.

They'd shown themselves—and well before we arrived in Sichuan.

In Anhui Province, not Zhejiang Province, where the Great Nation's capital and the Emperor's residence were located.

And they'd been disguised, unlike usual.

Why had the Embroidered Uniform Guard—an agency directly under the Emperor—appeared in Anhui Province in disguise, unlike usual?

We had no way to learn more. The informants who'd caught their scent and followed them had been found dead. But I couldn't help imagining the worst.

If they hadn't stopped in Anhui and had kept heading northwest…

That would take them to Shanxi Province. And he was in Shanxi Province.

Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao.

The only direct member of the imperial family the current Son of Heaven had spared after winning the horrific power struggle over the throne.

The only vassal king in the land and, with the Son of Heaven having no heir, the current successor to the Great Nation's throne.

But the Emperor, who'd been quiet until now, has set the Embroidered Uniform Guard in motion. And so secretly, too.

If their destination was Shanxi Province… I could only foresee the worst.

The shadow of Dark Heaven had reached the Great Nation's imperial family.

The Captain of the Guards said the City Lord of Sichuan Province had started showing signs of madness right after the Son of Heaven took his favorite concubine. And the Blood Soul Gu found in his body was so rare that I'd never even seen one in the Poisonblood Grounds in Nanman.

There was enough evidence. I silently stared up at the night sky, lit only by hazy moonlight.

A question that would reach no one.

What the hell are you after?

And then—

A faint sound came from somewhere in the sky and reached my ears.

No. It reached both our ears.

Flutter.

"Old Master."

"This is…"

It wasn't the wind. It was the beating of wings as something flew through it toward us.

A messenger pigeon!

The moment I realized it, Jeok Cheongang and I looked toward the distant sky. Our eyes widened.

Whooosh!

The shadows of more than ten birds raced toward us, cutting through the wind.

Chapter 853

Information is a puzzle. One piece alone can never give you the whole picture.

Unless you gather the pieces and fit them together, they're not information at all—just questions with no value.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard appearing in Anhui about fifteen days ago had been just such a piece.

At least, until the City Lord of Sichuan Province died suddenly and the Blood Soul Gu was discovered.

Things are different now.

Emei and Qingcheng belonged to the Nine Sects and One Gang. Then there were the Sichuan Tang Clan and the Beggars' Sect. Even the Lower District Sect, whose members were largely commoners, was a Murim organization.

With a full-scale war against Dark Heaven underway, information about the government had naturally fallen down their list of priorities.

If your own neighborhood was on fire, you'd have to be crazy to go looking around the one next door.

But if the fire spread there, that changed everything.

We needed to dig up every piece that, for one reason or another, had never been reported—or had been set aside as mere suspicion.

And the dozen or so messenger pigeons that had just arrived at the Sichuan Tang Clan were carrying those very pieces.

"Old Master. You're here. And you too."

Important matters went to the Family Head first, of course.

Tang Sadok greeted Jeok Cheongang and me briefly. In front of him lay a scattering of tightly sealed missives.

"Are those all… about this?"

"Probably."

At Tang Sadok's brief reply and glance, the old man beside him—who had been carefully inspecting the messenger pigeons and their missives—spoke up.

"From what I've seen, there's no sign the messenger pigeons were attacked, and none of the missives have been damaged."

"Are you certain? This is important."

"I stake my life on it."

"That's enough for me. I'll send for you when the time comes. Until then, don't let anyone in."

"Yes, Family Head. I won't let so much as a rat near."

The old man bowed politely and left the room. His presence quickly faded into the distance.

Tang Sadok caught the meaning in Jeok Cheongang's eyes and spoke first.

"He's a household retainer absolutely loyal to me. He's handled messenger pigeons here for more than half his life, so I had him check them as a precaution."

The place Tang Sadok called "here" looked less like a pavilion than a huge aviary.

Even standing still, the sharp, musty smell of birds stung my nose. Iron cages of all sizes filled the space, and feathers of every color fluttered through the air.

It was clear that this place had been used for years solely to train messenger pigeons and send and receive their messages. Dozens of unopened missives were piled up inside.

"There are more than I expected. A lot more missives than pigeons we saw on the way here."

Tang Sadok gave a small nod.

"I'm surprised, too. Usually, they send only the bare minimum of information to keep the messenger pigeons from attracting attention. But sending several pages on each one means…"

"They had that much information to send, even if this was the only way to do it."

Jeok Cheongang spoke up, then added quietly,

"And it was that urgent."

I opened the first missive and read it. What they'd said was no exaggeration.

"What does it say?"

I was silent for a moment before answering Jeok Cheongang.

"After Anhui, people suspected of being members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard appeared in Hubei."

"Hubei? When did the information come in?"

"About twenty days ago."

"Twenty days. Damn, that's late."

"By then, their trail in Anhui had already gone cold, and it seems neither the Beggars' Sect nor the Lower District Sect in Hubei guessed they were the Embroidered Uniform Guard."

Tang Sadok frowned.

"Isn't it possible they weren't the Embroidered Uniform Guard at all? If your guess is right and their target is Prince Shangshan, they'd have no reason to detour through Hubei to reach Shanxi. They could go straight from Anhui to Henan."

He was right. Anhui was closest to Henan, and they could enter Shanxi by heading just a little farther north.

But Tang Sadok had forgotten one important thing.

"If they *are* the Embroidered Uniform Guard, and they disguised themselves to hide their identities from the start, of course they'd avoid Henan."

"What does that mean…? Ah."

Tang Sadok let out a small exclamation.

"The Murim Alliance."

"Exactly. Their trail was nearly picked up even in Anhui. Henan is practically an impregnable fortress right now."

The vast storm of war was reaching its peak, and the full-scale war with Dark Heaven had begun.

With everyone in the Central Plains Murim on high alert, crossing Henan—the home of the Murim Alliance's headquarters—to reach Shanxi would be no different from giving away their identities.

The Murim Alliance wasn't made up of fools.

Dark Heaven's agents or the Embroidered Uniform Guard—it didn't matter. Anyone suspicious would be identified in no time.

Even if the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, leader of the Murim Alliance, merely stood by with a gentle smile and watched, one old fox beside him would be different.

Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox.

He had another title: Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.

At that very moment, as I pictured the Thousand-Faced Fox's face, always marked by a faint smile—

Rustle.

A faint sound came from the crack beneath the firmly shut door. But no one in the room, myself included, was surprised or flustered.

We'd already sensed someone approaching and had a fair idea who it was.

Creeeak.

At Jeok Cheongang's glance, I reached out. A gentle current of qi pushed the door open, revealing a person.

No—more accurately, two people who looked like one.

The Tang Family retainer who had left earlier had Namho pinned in an embrace from behind, a blade pressed to his Adam's apple.

"…?"

"…?"

"…?"

What the hell was going on?

My brain stalled for a moment, but the answer came quickly.

The Tang Family retainer who would do anything Tang Sadok said had been guarding the place so faithfully that not even a rat could get near. Then he'd found Namho.

The minor problem was that Namho had nearly died for it.

"You're still young at heart. It's not easy to get fired up at your age."

Namho, restrained with the retainer pressed up against his back, replied with a face like he'd bitten into a turd.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"Nothing. Anyway, stay still. Your Adam's apple moves when you talk, and the blade will cut you."

"There's a limit to how far you can take a threat—"

Slice.

"Fuck, it really does."

"I told you not to talk."

"That's why I'm using ventriloquism now."

"Oh, ventriloquism. Teach me sometime."

"Maybe, if I get the chance… Damn it. Cut the crap and get this man to stand down. I've explained, but he won't listen to a word."

Jeok Cheongang stroked his chin, looking amused by Namho's predicament.

"You were right about him being loyal. If he were just a little more reliable, he'd have killed an innocent man."

"…Sometimes his loyalty goes too far. Let him go. He's one of ours."

At Tang Sadok's sighing words, the retainer blinked, finally withdrew his dagger, and stepped back.

Namho watched him leave without so much as an apology and muttered,

"I've seen all kinds of lunatics, but this is something else. No wonder the Sichuan Tang Clan is—"

"Is what?"

Namho met Tang Sadok's pointed gaze and changed course at the speed of light.

"That of one of the Five Great Families under Heaven."

An impressive drift. Then again, however long you'd already lived, you wouldn't want to spend the rest of your life worrying about being poisoned.

"Anyway, why did you take so long? It's been ages since I sent for you."

"I was trying to remember something. Maybe I'm getting old, but my memory isn't what it used to be."

"Your memory?"

"Yes. My memory."

Before I could ask what he meant, Namho nodded toward the missive in my hand.

"That information you're reading—where did it come from?"

"The Hubei branches of the Beggars' Sect and the Lower District Sect."

"No, the one beside it."

I opened another of the dozens of missives scattered across the table and checked it.

"It says Hoyeon Trading Company. I've never heard of it. The contents say…"

"It's a trading company under the Qingcheng Sect. More precisely, Hoyeon Sword, a lay disciple of the Qingcheng Sect, has been running it for twenty years. He's a Peak master, but he's much better at running a trading company than at martial arts. Hoyeon Trading Company is one of the five largest in Shandong."

"What?"

"Oh, and you don't need to tell me what it says. I'm looking for a different name. Just check the source of each message and tell me."

"…"

I didn't know what to ask first.

As far as I knew, he hadn't set foot in the Central Plains since the Great Faction War. How did he know so much about something from twenty years ago?

And if he didn't care what the missives said, what source was he looking for?

Jeok Cheongang and Tang Sadok stared at him with wide eyes. I could only look at him, dumbfounded and silent. Namho clicked his tongue, displeased.

"I'm no Jiang Taigong. Did you think I spent all those years in Nanman just sitting around fishing? I kept up with news from the Central Plains through the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's Hidden Thread while I was there. There's nothing to be so surprised about."

"This seems like more than just keeping up with the news. Even if I heard some of that, I wouldn't remember it."

"Call it an old man's pastime. Anything else?"

It was probably closer to an occupational habit, but my curiosity about that didn't matter right now.

I kept quiet and hurriedly began opening and reading the remaining missives.

They'd all come through the Sichuan Branch, but each had a different source. And since I had to read them to find what Namho wanted, I began piecing together their contents as I went.

What emerged was shocking.

It wasn't just Anhui and Hubei.

Anhui, Hubei, Hunan, Jiangsu, Shandong.

If the missives were accurate, people suspected of being members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard had appeared in all five provinces, then vanished.

This is…

They were traveling in separate groups.

It looked less like an attempt to cause confusion than a way to move without attracting attention.

They had split into groups of between ten and thirty, scattered across the provinces, then disappeared upon reaching Shaanxi or Shandong.

Shanxi. They gathered in Shanxi.

There was no doubt. Avoiding Henan and drawing as little attention as possible, they'd gone around it, slipping into Shanxi through Shaanxi and Shandong—the provinces that lay along the continent's flank.

And in Shanxi…

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

My heart sank. I picked up another missive almost mechanically, and my teeth clenched as I read it.

Grind.

"What is it?"

"What does it say?"

Instead of answering, I unfolded the missive and held it out. Tiny characters covered the yellowed animal hide.

> 1. Sender: Shanxi Branch of the Lower District Sect.
> 2. Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao. Accompanied by the Embroidered Uniform Guard.
> 3. Hong Jin, Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province, second rank. Requested assistance from the Lower District Sect and joined Prince Shangshan.
> 4. Tracking commenced. Intervention by the authorities is a concern.
> 5. Operation suspended after the tracking team was wiped out.
> 6. This document is Heaven-grade. Deliver this information to the person designated by the client as quickly as possible.
> 7. Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. Urgent search requested.

One missive had turned suspicion into certainty.

Tang Sadok and Jeok Cheongang read it and let out quiet exclamations.

"…This is…"

"It was already five days ago. Given the distance, the Sichuan Branch must have received the information and forwarded it only today."

That was probably right. If I'd obtained this missive before we gathered at the Sichuan Tang Clan, I would've known about it already.

But we were a step too late. Prince Shangshan was already in the Embroidered Uniform Guard's hands. Behind the Guard stood the Son of Heaven. Or Dark Heaven.

No—maybe Dark Heaven is controlling the Son of Heaven.

It might have been a leap, but the Blood Soul Gu was reason enough to suspect it.

Baeksang, Great Chieftain of the Bai people and second-in-command of the Nanman Beast Palace, had been the same.

And if my suspicion was right…

We're finished. What happened in Nanman won't even compare.

The Nanman Beast Palace was a sect and a small kingdom.

But the Great Nation was exactly that: a great nation.

The size of the bomb, and how far the blast would reach when it went off, were on another scale entirely.

Just imagining it sent chills down my spine.

Before I knew it, I was walking toward Prince Shangshan, though I had no idea where he was.

Step.

"Where are you going in such a hurry?"

The voice belonged to neither Jeok Cheongang nor Tang Sadok.

I slowly turned. Namho was calmly reading a missive without so much as looking at me.

"We have to go. We need to protect Prince Shangshan."

"Fine. But where? East, toward the Imperial Capital? North, toward Shanxi? Surely you don't mean south or west."

Even through my confusion, I did my best to answer calmly.

"We'll head northeast for now. We can use the Beggars' Sect and the Lower District Sect to track them."

"Wrong."

"What? What do you mean…?"

I was baffled by his utterly firm tone. Namho said nothing, only holding out the missive in his hand.

> 1. Sender: Nakjo Escort Bureau.
> 2. Prince Shangshan and fifty members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard departed Shanxi Province.
> 3. Expected to travel through Shandong and Jiangsu toward Zhejiang.
> 4. At their current speed, they are expected to enter Jiangsu Province on the first day of next month.
> 5. Escort order issued. Person to be escorted: Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao. Assigned: Fire King Jeok Cheongang, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, and all members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

The moment I saw the words *escort order issued* on the last line, I knew where the missive had really come from.

Only one place in the world could give an order to me—or rather, to Jeok Cheongang.

“The Murim Alliance…!”

“The Hidden Shadow Pavilion, to be precise. Though it would have had the Alliance Leader’s approval.”

“The Nakjo Escort Bureau? What is this? I already checked every missive, so where did this even—”

My voice trailed off. The smell of blood reached me, and I turned toward it.

When had that happened? One of the messenger pigeons in a cage lay dead, its belly slit open.

“The Hidden Shadow Pavilion uses this method often. It’s unfair to the poor pigeon, but hiding a message in its belly is more secure for us.”

All of us stared at him, speechless. Namho smiled calmly and went on.

“Do we still have time to hesitate? There’s less than a fortnight until the first of the month. If we leave right now, we can catch up with Prince Shangshan in Jiangsu, at least.”

He was right. There was no more time to hesitate.

I shot off into the darkness.

We had a little over fifteen days left. We had to hurry, even if it was only by a single hour.

Chapter 854

Jang Il, a junior military officer in Hubei Province, knew how to be satisfied with his life.

Some people who knew him would click their tongues and say he had no ambition, despite being born a man. But Jang Il himself was proud of who he was.

I've done well enough. Damn right I have.

He'd been born into a commoner family with next to nothing, yet he'd risen to become an officer.

His low rank meant the government paid him a pittance, but what mattered was that he was one of the seven gate commanders in Yichang, a major city in western Hubei Province.

And what kind of place was Yichang?

A port city on the Yangtze, which ran across Hubei Province. Poets and scholars flocked there to admire its splendid scenery.

Countless people and goods passed through every day, and naturally, each gate collected hefty tolls.

There were also the little extras called bribes, which never found their way into reports to the higher-ups.

Wonder what big shots will come through today.

Jang Il rose early, eager to get ready for work.

He put on a silk robe with a lustrous sheen and belted on his finely decorated sword.

It stung a little that he couldn't see himself in a mirror—they were far too expensive for him to buy—but his elderly servant offered some comfort.

"You truly have the bearing of a hero, my lord."

"Ahem. You think so, too?"

"Yes, my lord. Whoever passes through the gate, none of them will dare raise their heads properly in the face of your authority."

"Now, now. What a silly thing to say."

For all his protests, the corners of Jang Il's mouth twitched upward. The elderly servant laughed and waved a hand.

"When have you ever known me to flatter you? But you're wearing your best silk robe and even carrying your sword today. Something important must be happening."

"You're always quick to catch on. Some real big shots might be coming through. A trading caravan that left for Chongqing about two months ago is due back around now."

"Goodness. But haven't things been getting strange around Chongqing lately?"

"Who told you that?"

"A traveling merchant I know. He said there's been a bloodbath among martial artists, not just around Chongqing, but in Guangxi as well…"

"It's all nonsense, so ignore it. I've heard a little about Guangxi myself, but Chongqing only has a few disorganized bandits and river pirates. This caravan is bound to bring in a fortune."

Jang Il straightened his clothes and smiled with satisfaction.

Chongqing lay between Sichuan Province and Hubei Province. It wasn't quite a province in its own right, but its abundant resources and local specialties had countless trading companies eager to do business there.

The profits were high, and so was the competition. The trading companies that won out were enormous.

Especially this caravan.

Three trading companies had joined forces. Between their guards and caravan porters, they'd brought a staggering five hundred people.

They'd loaded more than a hundred carts onto ten merchant ships and set out about two months ago. Jang Il couldn't help looking forward to the little extras coming his way.

After everything it took to get this post, I ought to get something out of it.

The old saying "you reap what you sow" meant something entirely different to Jang Il.

He'd scattered a fortune in bribes to become a gate commander in Yichang. In less than two years, he'd collected more than he'd spent, but he had no intention of stopping there.

As long as I keep collecting like this, that's plenty. No need to get greedy. Just enough to buy a respectable estate.

One greed was soon forgotten in pursuit of another.

Proud to be a conscientious official who was only moderately corrupt and moderately lazy, Jang Il left home.

The moment he arrived at his post at the West Gate, he realized something was wrong.

What is this?

The air felt taut.

The soldiers who would usually be standing around yawning with their arms folded were drenched in sweat and running in every direction. Bloodied stretchers and charred debris lay scattered about.

So did the three flags that had flown proudly when the caravan left for Chongqing two months ago.

"What on earth…"

“My lord! Officer Jang!”

The sudden call snapped Jang Il out of his daze.

A familiar subordinate stood before him, pale as a sheet.

“What—what happened here?”

“Th-that is…”

“Tell me the truth, now!”

The subordinate flinched at his superior’s sharp shout, then stammered out an answer.

As Jang Il listened to his rambling account, his mouth fell open.

“A-an attack?”

“Yes, my lord. They say the caravan was attacked by bandits on its way back.”

“That’s impossible! They had five hundred guards and caravan porters! What bandits would be mad enough to attack them?”

Just as his horrified shout rang out—

“The world’s gone mad. Why should bandits be any different?”

A weary voice cut in. Jang Il turned toward it and blinked.

“M-Master of the Trading Company?”

There was no mistaking him. Even drenched in blood, with his clothes reduced to rags, Jang Il recognized him at once.

He was one of the three trading company masters who had joined the caravan—the big shot Jang Il had been waiting for these past two months.

“Glad I survived to see you again, Officer Jang.”

“W-what on earth happened? Where are the other two?”

“They came with us. But we’ll never have the chance to speak again.”

Jang Il followed the man’s pointing finger and felt the world go dark.

Several dozen bodies lay wrapped in straw mats. Two had been set apart from the rest. It was all too clear who they were.

“…Surely not.”

“Just what you think. They fought bravely to the end, but there was nothing we could do. We were simply outnumbered.”

“Outnumbered? There were that many bandits?”

“Bandits and river pirates, to be precise. Even in the confusion of the ambush, I could tell. Men with harpoons were swarming everywhere.”

“R-river pirates? How could they…?”

“Whether they’re in the mountains or on the Yangtze, thieves make their living by thieving, don’t they?”

The trading company master muttered wearily and leaned against a shattered cart.

“Everything went smoothly when we left Yichang two months ago. But as soon as we reached Chongqing, I had a feeling something was wrong. Sure enough, we’d barely set foot on Yuhua Mountain when they appeared.”

Despite its beautiful scenery, Yuhua Mountain was known as one of Chongqing’s rugged mountains.

The trading company master remembered the moment they’d first encountered their enemies, hemmed in by narrow paths and dense brush. He shuddered before he could stop himself.

“We thought nothing could stand in our way. Each company had brought only its best men, and we’d hired dozens of renowned wandering martial artists in case of trouble. But the moment the attackers appeared, I knew none of that mattered.”

“How many were there?”

“A thousand.”

“Pardon?”

“I said a thousand. That was only what I could count at a glance. There must have been more.”

“…!”

For a moment, Jang Il thought he’d misheard.

A band of more than a thousand bandits? In the north, nomads or mounted bandits based on the grasslands sometimes joined forces and invaded with a large army. But not in Chongqing.

Something unprecedented had happened. Something that should never have happened.

“But haven’t things been getting strange around Chongqing lately?”

“Who told you that?”

“A traveling merchant I know. He said there’s been a bloodbath among martial artists, not just around Chongqing, but in Guangxi as well…”

Remembering the conversation he’d had with his elderly servant before leaving home, Jang Il felt his heart sink.

His cherished silk robe was damp with cold sweat, though he had no idea when he’d started sweating.

No way.

Chongqing was right next to Hubei. From Yichang, where he commanded a gate, it was three days by boat or five by land.

If—if all of this is true…

His hands and feet trembled. His breathing quickened.

He should’ve been on his feet, directing the soldiers and sounding the alarm, but his body wouldn’t move.

Whether he noticed Jang Il's condition or not, the trading company master continued.

"We told them we'd pay the toll. Their answer was a volley of arrows."

Someone died, and a fierce battle began.

The fighters trained by the trading companies and the hired wandering martial artists fought back. Even the caravan porters who had been hauling the carts joined in. But the river pirates and bandits, who'd spent their whole lives as raiders, cut them down without hesitation.

"It was less a battle than a slaughter. We had plenty of people, but half were caravan porters. The rest could only do so much."

"But how? Weren't most of those men slash-and-burn farmers or fishermen to begin with?"

"Probably. But there was something different about them. They kept charging at us like they were possessed."

The trading company master had been speaking as calmly as he could, but now his voice began to shake.

"Even with their legs slashed or an arm gone, they kept coming. Knock one down, and three more came. Knock three down, and five more appeared. If we swallowed our fear and brought them down too, ten more were waiting. Again and again…"

The trading company master still remembered it clearly.

No—he would remember them until his dying breath.

They had charged like fiends bursting out of a hellscape.

"The battle ended decisively in just half a shichen—roughly an hour—and our side broke. Men started running in every direction. Surrounded by screams and death, I led my subordinates away, too. The caravan had failed, but we had to get out alive somehow."

Nothing was more precious than life.

He had retreated with the other two trading company masters and the men they had left. By the time they emerged from Yuhua Mountain, their number had fallen from five hundred to half that.

"We kept running along the mountain foothills. For three whole days."

"Th-three days?"

"We wanted to go down and ask the imperial troops or another Murim sect for help, but with those men watching, it was nearly impossible. Staying on the move was our best option."

The enemy had been watching the main routes closely. The survivors, barely clinging to life, had made a break for Hubei along the shortest route and finally escaped Chongqing.

Or so they thought.

Then they came out of Yuhua Mountain and saw the ten merchant ships they'd left at the nearest dock burning.

"I was sure it was over. I couldn't even bring myself to think about running anymore."

The three-day pursuit had been brutal. From five hundred, they had fallen to half that. From that half, to fewer than a hundred. They thought of death as they watched their last hope—the merchant ships—sink amid dark red flames.

Behind them, the enemy shouted.

And just as their final battle was about to begin, people no one could have expected appeared.

"A middle-aged man. He had about ten people with him."

"A middle-aged man…?"

"Yes. He walked toward us as if out for a stroll, pointed at the burning ships, and asked us this out of the blue."

The trading company master steadied his breathing and continued.

"Which son of a bitch set those on fire?"

Chapter 855

“Which son of a bitch set the fire?”

A low, weighty voice.

Hyuk Mujin swept the area with a gaze sharp as a blade, then shuddered with a gasp.

“Damn. Just thinking about that moment makes me feel like I’m going to piss myself! As expected of Great Hero Je—”

“Shut your mouth and sit down before I beat you so badly you piss and shit yourself.”

“Yes, sir.”

“That mouth of his never takes a break. Was he like this in Nanman, too?”

At Jeok Cheongang’s weary question, Ju Hwaran answered cautiously.

“Yes. Hyuk Mujin has always been like that.”

“I wish I had a muzzle for him. It’s enough to drive me mad that I can’t get one out here.”

Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue and looked around, but no solution presented itself. They were traveling along a forest path surrounded by grass and trees.

They did encounter the occasional person, but what kind of lunatic would carry a muzzle fit for a human up a mountain?

“I have one. Would you like it?”

“…?”

There was such a lunatic.

And he was right beside him.

“Why on earth are you carrying something like that?”

At Jeok Cheongang’s bewildered question, Namho lowered his voice.

“Doesn’t everyone have at least one person they’d like to put a muzzle on?”

“…You’re quite something yourself.”

“Anyway, if you need it, just say the word. I won’t give it to you outright, of course. I’ll lend it to you for a little while. I need to use it myself as soon as I get the chance.”

Namho glanced meaningfully over his shoulder. Not far away, by a stream, Taishan was staring into the water, looking close to tears.

“Taishan can’t find it. Taishan needs old, smart Namho’s help.”

“Hm.”

No matter how much you disliked someone, you couldn’t spit in the face of a smile.

Namho had been ready to scold him the moment their eyes met, but his voice softened a little.

“I’m not sure I like that first part… Fine. What do you need help with?”

“Taishan is looking for meat, but can’t see any. Namho is smart, unlike Taishan.”

“You’ve said nothing but true things today. But what were you sitting there waiting to catch? Carp? Crucian carp?”

“Neither.”

“Then what?”

“Five-spice pork.”

“Fuck…!”

Namho snatched up a rock and charged at Taishan like a mad bison, but he didn’t get far.

At a glance from Jeok Cheongang, Sama Pyo and Song Ilseom appeared like streaks of light and seized his arms from either side.

“Let go! Let go of me! You brats are still wet behind the ears!”

“Calm down, Elder Namho.”

“We don’t want to do this either.”

“I’m going to count to three. It would be in your best interest to release this old man before something irreversible happens. Now. One, two, two and a half. Two and three-quarters…”

Namho never made it to three. As he was dragged into the undergrowth, Hyuk Mujin watched him go and murmured sadly,

“That’s a shame. I’d grown quite attached to him.”

“What are you talking about? Anyone listening would think we were actually going to kill him.”

“Wait, we aren’t? I thought Great Hero Jeok had already given the order.”

“…”

What kind of man did this idiot take him for?

Flustered by Jeok Cheongang’s blazing stare, Hyuk Mujin began to ramble.

“I mean, a few days ago, you cut down all those bandits. Every last one of them.”

“What am I, a butcher? ‘Cut them down’? And they weren’t all bandits. There were river pirates, too.”

“Isn’t that the same thing?”

“They’re entirely different. Though that doesn’t change the fact that every one of them deserved to die.”

“Because they set the fire?”

“Of course… No. Because they harmed innocent people.”

Jeok Cheongang hurriedly corrected himself, but that only confirmed Hyuk Mujin’s suspicion.

It was because they set the fire. That’s why he killed them.

Strangely, of all the sins in the world, Jeok Cheongang considered arson the worst.

Perhaps that made sense. During the Great Faction War, he'd refused even Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's request to join the orthodox faction. It was the Demonic Cult setting fires that had finally brought him out into the world.

The battle three days ago had been for exactly that reason.

Actually, it's embarrassing to even call that a battle.

Hyuk Mujin revised his thought.

It hadn't been a battle. It had been a massacre.

It was that one-sided, and that brutal.

Some three hundred bandits and river pirates had been wiped out in less than an hour.

Afterward, Hyuk Mujin and the others had left, barely listening to the trading company masters from Hubei thank them.

They'd taken the only merchant ship that had somehow survived the flames as payment for saving their lives.

Of course, they hadn't asked for the other party's consent. But anyway, that was what happened.

"Oh, come to think of it, those people must have reached Hubei by now, right?"

"Why are you suddenly changing the subject?"

"Those people. The ones we saved."

"…Is that something a man who barely swung his sword a couple of times should say?"

"But I did swing it."

The nerve of him.

Jeok Cheongang glared at Hyuk Mujin in disbelief, then shook his head.

From what he'd seen, every last member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion was out of his mind. If he thought too hard about them, the infirmities of old age he'd barely managed to cure might come back.

I suppose I should be grateful there's at least one normal person among them.

Jeok Cheongang glanced to the side. There stood Ju Hwaran, the only person he could call sane in this madhouse.

The more I see her, the more I like her.

It had been seven days and nights since they'd left the Sichuan Tang Clan as though something were chasing them.

They'd traveled day and night, sticking to remote, rugged terrain to avoid attracting attention. Yet Ju Hwaran hadn't complained once. She'd stayed cheerful throughout.

As the only woman in the group, she must have faced any number of difficulties.

She's clearly kept up with her martial arts training, and her character is upright, too. The Escort King has himself one fine granddaughter.

Plenty of young people mistook recklessness for a virtue.

And not just street thugs. Even among the disciples of great sects hailed as young prodigies, fools were everywhere.

They relied on their natural talent instead of working hard, then strutted around trading on their sects' prestige.

Jeok Cheongang had seen so many of them that he was sick of the type. It only made Ju Hwaran more admirable in his eyes.

Though he couldn't claim he was entirely without an ulterior motive.

Even the ones swaggering around as Elders and Sect Leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang now were a whole basket of no-good brats when they were young. Compared to them, Hwaran is more than Jin Taekyung deserves… No. What's he lacking? He's handsome, well-built, and there's no need to mention his martial arts.

A fierce battle raged in his head.

He was already slurping noodle broth before anyone had even thought of offering him a rice cake[3312] when a voice startled him out of it.

"Great Hero Jeok, are you all right?"

"Hm? What?"

"You looked troubled, so I was wondering…"

"Ah. Ahem."

Jeok Cheongang had nearly answered without thinking. He hurriedly cleared his throat instead.

The girl wasn't merely young enough to be his granddaughter. She was young enough to be his *great*-granddaughter. He didn't want her catching him indulging an old man's foolish notions.

"It's nothing. I was just thinking about how far we have left to Jiangsu."

"Oh. At our current pace, we'll arrive within five days. Even if something delays us, I'd expect it to take about seven days."

"How can you be so sure?"

"I came through this area on an escort mission two years ago. I brought a map that's been passed down from my grandfather's time, too."

"Ho. Impressive. Very impressive."

"Thank you. But I'm not worthy of such high praise from you, Great Hero Jeok."

They said she'd led the Escort Bureau for several years in place of her father, who had been bedridden until recently. Her answer was every bit as crisp as he'd expect.

[3312] This adapts a Korean saying about drinking kimchi soup before being offered rice cakes—assuming an outcome before it is settled.

Ju Hwaran seemed unsure what to do with the sudden praise, and Jeok Cheongang smiled fondly.

"You've thought everything through. So capable, unlike that brat."

"Pardon? What do you mean…?"

"I was just talking to myself. Still, the more I hear you address me that way, the more stiff it sounds. From now on, you can just call me Grandpa—"

Jeok Cheongang glanced at Ju Hwaran and changed course.

Even he had to admit that *Grandfather* was too soon. Relationships had to begin slowly, one step at a time.

If he got ahead of himself and made Ju Hwaran wary, it would surely affect her relationship with his one and only Disciple, too.

"…No. Call me Old Master."

"Really?"

The only people who called Jeok Cheongang that were those who had known his predecessors, or the heads of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

Ju Hwaran's eyes widened at the unexpected offer. Hyuk Mujin, who'd been listening, broke into a broad smile and chimed in.

"Thank you, Old Master. I thought the same thing—that the way I address you is too stiff…"

"Would you rather be hit by this old man's fist, which is harder than a rock, or keep your mouth shut?"

"…"

"You may not call me that. Don't even dream of it."

Jeok Cheongang fixed Hyuk Mujin with a fierce glare. He had never been more emphatic.

"Come on. Why are you picking on the poor kid?"

The voice came from far away, yet sounded as clear as if the speaker stood right before them.

But Jeok Cheongang had known who it was before he heard a word.

A faint footstep and the sound of breathing—too subtle for even a Peak master with deep internal energy to hear. That alone had told him.

It wouldn't have mattered if he weren't known as the Fire King, or if he weren't a Supreme Peak master.

A master always knew his one and only disciple.

"Hmph. Look at that slowpoke."

Jeok Cheongang frowned out of habit, hiding his delight as best he could. He made sure his voice was gruff, too—a far cry from how he'd spoken to Ju Hwaran.

“What took you so long? Why are you only crawling back now? I’ve been waiting half a day because of you.”

“Half a day?”

Hyuk Mujin rushed toward Jin Taekyung shouting, “Captain!” Taekyung kicked him hard in the shin and gave a disbelieving laugh.

“That’s a bit much. Half a day? It’s been half an hour at most. Right?”

The Divine Physician followed behind him, carrying a bundle stuffed with needles and medicinal herbs. He answered with composure.

“I’ll refrain from commenting, Young Hero Jin.”

“Why?”

“Isn’t it obvious? There’s no point answering when there’s no reasoning with him anyway…”

“Wow. So you’re not called the Divine Physician just for your medical skills. You’ve got insight, too.”

“You’re too kind. It’s simply something anyone would learn from experience.”

“…What the fuck is wrong with you two?”

Jeok Cheongang eyed them both. Instead of laying into them, he clicked his tongue.

One way or another, that rude young brat was his one and only Disciple, whom he couldn’t bring himself to hate. And the old man right beside him was a physician who’d agreed to travel a long way to treat that young brat.

What more could he say?

All he could do was pretend nothing was wrong, hide his worry, and ask this:

How are you feeling?

Jin Taekyung heard Jeok Cheongang’s Sound Transmission and gave a quiet laugh as he nodded.

Jeok Cheongang couldn’t tell whether Taekyung truly felt all right or was only pretending. But if what the Divine Physician had said earlier was true, there had to have been at least some improvement.

He’s all right for now. I don’t know when he’ll hit a wall, but… I’ll do everything I can to find a way.

Noticing Jeok Cheongang had fallen silent, Jin Taekyung gave a faint, rueful smile. He stretched his stiff body and spoke.

“How much farther? Three days? Four?”

Ju Hwaran answered as though she’d been waiting for him to ask.

“About three days.”

“Three days… There’s still time before the first of the month, but it’s going to be close.”

Jin Taekyung looked somewhere to the east.

“Let’s cut that down to two days.”

Chapter 856

Seven days and nights passed in the blink of an eye after we left the Sichuan Tang Clan.

The scenery and the people around us changed with every step.

But it was too soon to relax.

Despite my boast that we'd cut the remaining time down to two days, reality was less accommodating. The deeper we went to avoid drawing attention, the more time we lost.

"We'll have to pick up the pace."

"Even faster than this?"

"Yes. Faster than I thought we'd have to."

"If we keep up this pace, we can arrive by the first of the month. We're already pushing ourselves too hard."

"I know. But do you think the Embroidered Uniform Guard is any different from us?"

"…!"

"We're not the only ones on the move. We have to push ourselves and get in their way before they reach their destination."

Jeok Cheongang already knew I was right, so he said nothing.

Information was important. But perfect information didn't exist.

If we'd picked up some information, then so had our opponents.

That was true even in the modern world, where information could be relayed by the minute or even the second. How much more so in Murim?

Wherever we went, we were still within the Great Nation's territory. With eyes and ears everywhere, there had been countless variables from the start. There was only one way to minimize them.

Move as fast as possible. Run ourselves into the ground.

Of course, that meant enduring tremendous hardship.

We were trying to cross half the continent in a little over half a month. It was insane.

"Captain, we're actually going to die at this rate."

"Then we should rest."

"Really?"

"Sure. In Jiangsu."

"No, I'm not joking. I mean we're going to die!"

"Mujin. Hyuk Mujin."

"Yes?"

“If we don’t go, what do you think will happen?”

“…”

“If you want to rest, rest. I’m not being sarcastic or hinting at anything. If you think you can’t go on, drop out. It’ll be better for all of us.”

Hyuk Mujin said nothing after that.

No—neither did anyone else.

Instead of complaining, they held their tongues and kept moving.

We crossed rugged mountain ranges and forded winding rivers.

The vast continent’s climate and terrain varied a little from one region to the next.

The midday heat in Hubei was like a blast furnace, while the night wind in Anhui cut like a cold blade.

One day, after wind and rain had swept through, some of the party collapsed from exhaustion.

“Young Hero Jin, I understand how important this matter is, but… we can’t go on any longer.”

The Divine Physician had watched the others wear themselves down. I gave him a short answer.

“We’ll rest for fifteen minutes, then set out again.”

I carried Hyuk Mujin on my back, and Jeok Cheongang carried Ju Hwaran.

Both refused at first, but this time I wouldn’t budge. One look told me they were in no condition to say they were fine, even as a joke.

Of course they’re exhausted. We’ve been moving until their internal energy and stamina were spent.

And though his title was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang was a man of cold disposition. For some reason, he felt sorry for Ju Hwaran, who was burning up from head to toe despite the Divine Physician’s treatment.

“Is this really necessary? We could—”

“If you’re about to suggest the two of us travel separately, I’ll refuse right now.”

“Why?”

“Because we have to make it through this together. If we can’t endure even this much, we’ll die before long anyway.”

This wasn’t for my sake. It was for all of us.

The war had already begun, and upheaval lurked on every side.

Catastrophes more terrible and vast than anything anyone had ever faced.

To survive the war against Dark Heaven, all of us had to grow stronger—not just me. A blade hammered and tempered countless times won’t break even when it strikes a rock.

Jeok Cheongang was one of the very few people who understood what I meant better than anyone.

He, too, had been remade through bone-deep effort and hardship. In the end, he'd become a peerless blade that cut through countless rocks blocking his way.

"We have to make it through this together…"

Jeok Cheongang slowly repeated my words, then gave a dry chuckle.

"You've grown up."

"I've always been taller than you, Old Master. Then and now."

Jeok Cheongang shook his head at my answer.

"You're still an arrogant brat. Then and now."

"Isn't that part of my charm?"

"But no matter how I look at it, this is too much. You heartless little bastard."

"Miss Ju wanted it. I respected her wishes. If she were in enough pain to actually die, I'd have stopped her myself."

"Cut the crap. Anyway, your idea might be right, but I can be sure of one thing."

"Yes? What?"

"This old man guarantees you'll never find a partner as long as you live."

"Where did that come from?"

"Enough. If you have the energy to flap your gums, take one more step."

Jeok Cheongang dealt that brutal blow out of nowhere and darted away like the wind. As I watched him go, I noticed the world growing brighter and raised my head.

This is…

I gathered my internal energy and pushed off the ground. Stepping onto a branch of the nearest great tree, I sprang up above it. At last, I saw the light spreading in the distance.

It was the dawn light.

The eleventh dawn I'd seen since we'd left the Sichuan Tang Clan.

But what made the light of this new morning so welcome was something coming into view beyond the grass and streams that surrounded us.

"Ah."

A faint exclamation rang in my ears.

Hyuk Mujin, still on my back, asked in a half-dead voice, "C-Captain. Where are we? What's that?"

I laughed out loud.

Then I answered loudly enough for everyone below the tree to hear.

"Jiangsu."

Empires are majestic and great.

But they can never last forever.

Not so long ago, by the continent's standards, the empire founded by the nomads of the grasslands had been no different.

Each was a fine warrior and herdsman. They worshiped heaven and earth and were close companions to hawks and horses, but they were not good rulers.

A little over a hundred years.

That was all it took for the vast empire founded by the invaders from the grasslands to fall.

There had been a great conqueror who was both hero and devil, destined to remain a legend to the very end. There had also been a wise ruler who strengthened the empire from within and cared for his subjects and people.

But at the end of that age, all that remained were terrible famine, corruption, and countless red flags fluttering in the wind.

"You who hunger, rise up!"

An age of war began. People with blood-red flags and headscarves rose like wildfire on every side and swept across the continent.

The world called them the Red Turbans—bandits. They wanted to be called the Red Turban Army, but the world's judgment was closer to the truth.

They were bandits.

Bandits who stole grain and valuables to fill their empty stomachs.

Bandits who wanted to steal this nation's mountains and rivers, too.

"How can the blood of kings, nobles, generals, and ministers be any different from anyone else's?"

They might have been shabby on the outside, but did that mean there was nothing great within them?

Steal a handful of millet and you're a bandit. Steal a continent and you become the Son of Heaven.

Just as one hero had done at the end of that long age of war, when he finally seized all under heaven.

"My king, please ascend the imperial throne!"

And so a new heaven opened.

Born the son of a poor farmer, he had wandered the land as a mendicant monk. Now he held all under heaven in his hands and stood above everyone, with countless officials and commoners beneath him.

But even after many years had passed and one of his children inherited the throne, nothing changed.

At least, not for one boy living in Jiangsu.

"Hey, you beggar brat!"

Beggar brat.

It was one of the things he'd heard most often in his life. Even now, decades later, that moment was etched clearly into his mind.

It appeared without fail whenever he had a nightmare like this one.

"…Ah."

Hong Jin woke with a start and blinked. Then he respectfully bowed his head to the boy who had been watching him in silence.

"I dared to dream in Your Highness's presence. Please forgive your unfaithful servant."

The boy, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, replied.

"Forgive you? Don't be absurd."

His composure and dignified voice were hard to believe in someone not yet in his midteens.

The young prince, much taller and more solidly built than most boys his age, continued speaking to his servant.

"If anyone should apologize, it's me, not you. I've put a loyal subject through so much hardship."

"Hardship? I beg Your Highness to take back those words."

"No. This is all because of my own shortcomings."

"Your Highness…"

"But set aside your worries. What you fear will never happen."

Hong Jin answered by bringing his hands together and bowing deeply.

But as he stared at the floor of the slowly moving carriage, his gaze held both pride in the young prince and a hint of bitterness.

I earnestly pray it will be so as well, Your Highness… But your elder brother will not see it that way.

Hong Jin forced down the voice rising deep in his heart.

His master, Prince Shangshan, had been an intelligent, mature boy from a young age. But he was far too young to understand the cruelty of the world.

Even now, surrounded by the Embroidered Uniform Guard and bound for the Imperial Capital as though he were a prisoner under escort, he still had unwavering faith in his only blood relative.

Hong Jin did not.

You already have all under heaven. What more could you possibly want, Emperor?

With that question, which would reach no one, Hong Jin closed his eyes.

In the pitch-darkness, memories surfaced. Sounds returned.

The days when the blood never dried. The days of purges, when hundreds died with their limbs torn from their bodies and thousands were beheaded, their heads put on display.

And the late Emperor's final words.

"Bao. I entrust that child to you."

Thump.

A small jolt ran through the carriage. Hong Jin opened his eyes, turned, and saw someone's profile through a gap in the window.

"What's going on?"

At Hong Jin's low question, the man beside the carriage replied. He wore shabby martial robes that hardly suited the name Embroidered Uniform Guard.

"None of your business."

His voice was blunt, devoid of emotion. But Hong Jin sensed a cold blade beneath it.

A feeling both strange and familiar.

Hong Jin had once served as the late Emperor's hands and feet, just as the Embroidered Uniform Guard did now. The man's voice brought back a sensation he hadn't felt in over a decade.

Along with a hint of puzzlement.

Why have we stopped?

This covert procession had already entered Jiangsu, and the Embroidered Uniform Guard had no reason to stop. They were people who would gladly give their lives to carry out the Emperor's orders.

Something's going on.

Hong Jin quietly sharpened his senses. He might not have mastered martial arts to the point of founding his own school, but he had learned them.

Fortunately, the guards seemed to decide the matter didn't warrant Sound Transmission. Their conversation drifted through the gap in the window.

"According to the scouts, there's an unidentified corpse about three hundred zhang[3313] ahead…"

"They didn't get close in case it was a trap, but they couldn't see any obvious wounds…"

"It could be an attempt to split up our forces. We'll keep moving. Stay close to the carriage."

The murmuring conversation abruptly stopped. After a brief pause, the carriage started moving again.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

As he listened to the quiet sound of hooves, Hong Jin thought,

An unidentified corpse.

It wasn't so strange. The continent was vast, and people wandered its roads begging for food. Even Jiangsu, so close to the Imperial Capital, was no exception.

[3313] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese unit of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three hundred zhang is about 909 m (0.56 mi).

Why did one man’s name suddenly come to mind at this very moment?

And why did an inexplicable hope well up in one corner of his heart?

Could it be…

Hong Jin had just lifted his head when—

“Didn’t you say it was a corpse…?”

One of the Embroidered Uniform Guard had muttered the words. Then a voice Hong Jin recognized reached his ears.

“Captain. I swear I wasn’t dozing off. I was just lying down for a second… Huh? Who are you?”

At that moment, Hong Jin burst out laughing, briefly forgetting that the young prince was right in front of him.

Chapter 857

"What? Where'd everyone go? Hey, mister. Have you seen anyone around here?"

His hair was matted with grease, and his face was streaked with grime.

As the young man got to his feet and babbled, the man he'd called "mister" spoke.

"What happened? He doesn't look dead to me."

"I-I'm sorry. He was sleeping so soundly he looked dead, and I mistook him for—"

"That's enough. We'll discuss it when we return to the palace."

The Embroidered Uniform Guard martial artist who had reported the scouts' findings went rigid.

He knew what kind of man his superior was. He'd served under him for nearly three years. He also knew how seriously the man took this mission.

If he was lucky, he'd be demoted. If things went badly, he could be stripped of his position altogether.

Damn it.

He bit down on his lip and struggled to suppress his anger. He couldn't deny that he felt wronged, but a mistake was still a mistake.

He couldn't put spilled water back where it came from, but he could at least wipe it up.

No—he had to. If only to lessen the punishment coming his way.

"…I'll take care of it."

He spoke in a subdued voice and stepped toward the young man, who still looked half asleep.

The fellow was some beggar who could've wandered in from anywhere. If he resisted, one stroke of the sword would be enough.

At least, that was what the martial artist thought.

"What are you doing?"

Thud.

At his superior's sudden call, he stopped dead. The man looked down at him with calm, cold eyes, and he stammered out a reply.

"I—it can't be left like this, so I thought I'd handle it myself…"

"Handle it?"

"Y-Yes."

"How?"

Pardon?

"I asked how you intend to handle it."

"Well… given the situation, shouldn't we use force if necessary to eliminate the threat?"

The man was silent for a moment.

“How many years have you served?”

“I’ve served you for almost three years, Commander Jeong. And…”

The martial artist hesitated, watching his superior’s expression, then added, “As my father advised me, I believe I’ve always done my best to follow your orders.”

There was a little unease in his voice, and far more resentment.

His superior had barely given him a second look in nearly three years. Worse, he treated him as though being the son of a prestigious family meant nothing.

How much did my family spend to get me into the Embroidered Uniform Guard?

Gold, silver, and influence could reach anywhere—even the Embroidered Uniform Guard, which answered directly to the Emperor.

A rigorous screening meant that even a fortune could buy him no more than a low-ranking position. Still, plenty of people would have given anything to get that far.

He had no intention of backing down. Mentioning his father had been a warning: a reminder to his difficult, strict superior of the family standing behind him.

Which made the man’s next words all the harder to believe.

“Three years. That’s long enough.”

Pardon?

“Hand over your badge right now and go where you belong. This will conclude your punishment for the mistake you made earlier.”

“…!”

“What? Do you still have something to say?”

The martial artist stared at him, eyes wide, then burst out, “What? How can you do something so outrageous? Have you forgotten who I am—”

“I remember perfectly. Otherwise, I wouldn’t have kept you under me for three years.”

The man cut him off and continued in the same calm voice.

“But what people remember isn’t you. It’s the prestige of the family behind you. If you don’t want to make the same mistake again, take that to heart.”

“Are you done?”

“No, but there’s no point saying the rest. Especially to someone who can’t even tell whom he’s dealing with.”

“What the hell are you—”

He was about to shout when a voice reached his ear.

“Excuse me. Sorry to interrupt, but could I have some water first? I’ve been thirsty for a while.”

“…!”

The voice hadn’t come from a distance.

It was right behind him—close enough for him to catch the sweetish scent on the speaker's breath.

How did he—?!

Every hair on his body stood on end. He spun around like lightning and drew the sword at his waist.

Shing—whoosh!

The treasured sword passed down through his family for generations flashed with five-colored light as it split the figure behind him clean in half.

Or so he thought.

Just as the blade was about to bite into the top of the young man's head, two hands filthy with streaming grime moved in a flash.

Clang!

The young man brought his palms together with a deafening crash. A gasp escaped the martial artist.

"Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade…?"

It was a technique a master might show someone a level or two beneath him.

The martial artist had reached the Supreme First Rate realm thanks to his family's unstinting support. He understood at once what it meant and stared in shock at the man he'd taken for a mere beggar.

"A Peak master!"

At that horrified cry, the mysterious Peak master answered, "What the fuck are you talking about? I get shit all the time for being the guy who can't even use Sword Energy."

"Y-You! Who are you? State your identity!"

"Fuck off. Give me water, not a sword."

Whoosh—thud!

It happened in an instant.

The young man swept aside the sword caught between his palms and drove his hard knee into the martial artist's face. As the man crumpled like a rotten log, the young man found a small flask in his robes and drank it down in one go.

Gulp, gulp.

"Ahhh. Now I feel alive."

He looked as though he hadn't had a drop of water in days.

Commander Jeong watched him empty the flask and shake it for the last drops before speaking.

"I suspected as much when I first saw you. You're quite skilled."

The young man stared into the empty flask as though liquor might appear if he waited long enough. Then he asked, "Do you mean that?"

“Of course. You don’t seem to have reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy, but the movement you just showed was extremely efficient and impressive.”

“Thanks. Hearing that from someone way more skilled than me almost brings a tear to my eye. Though I could do without you talking down to me.”

“You misunderstand. I wasn’t mocking you.”

“I know. I didn’t misunderstand. I really do feel like I’m about to cry.”

“…?”

“I’ve been through so much fucking shit, taken every insult anyone could throw at me. I train my ass off, and all I ever hear is, ‘Why can’t you use Sword Energy?‘ and ‘How can you call yourself a proper person if you can’t even do that?‘ And now they’ve gone and left me on the side of the road, too… Ahem. Hic!”

Commander Jeong fell silent.

The young man’s complaints had poured out as though he’d been waiting for the chance, and now tears were streaming down his face. Everyone there had the same question.

What the hell is that guy?

He looked exactly like a beggar. Apparently, he was a lunatic.

The problem was that the lunatic was skilled. He was only Supreme First Rate, yet he moved like a Peak master.

And they were in the middle of an operation.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard martial artists lined up behind Commander Jeong exchanged bewildered looks.

What are we supposed to do in a situation like this?

I don’t know. Captain Hong might know.

I don’t know, either.

How can you not know, Captain Hong? You’re our Captain.

Does a Captain have to be some kind of god? Still, Senior Officer Gal should know. He’s been around much longer than I have.

No. I don’t know, either…

Pardon?

Their gazes wandered, and their mouths went dry.

When had the famed Embroidered Uniform Guard ever dealt with anything like this? The lunatic had sat down in the road and was sobbing at the top of his lungs. None of them knew what to do with him.

None of them except one.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

Commander Jeong slowly rode forward and looked down at the young man with his usual calm gaze.

“Are you done crying?”

The young man answered in a tear-choked voice.

“I’ve still got a little left.”

“That doesn’t matter. You’re delaying us. Move aside.”

“Mm.”

The young man sniffled.

“That might be difficult.”

“Why?”

“Moving aside would be easy enough, but the person I serve would be furious.”

“I thought you said you’d been abandoned.”

“Sometimes I get left behind when I’m with that person. Anyway, I don’t know why I ended up here, but they’ll be back soon.”

Brush, brush.

The young man stood and dusted off his backside.

“Believe it or not, I’m his right-hand man. Though I might just be his little toe.”

“I see.”

Commander Jeong gave a slight nod.

“Do you have an identity tag?”

“An identity tag? Is that something you boil in soup?”

“So you’re a rogue of the martial world. You treat the strict laws established by the Son of Heaven as nonsense.”

“Something like that. Why ask all of a sudden?”

“It’s merely a check. I can’t harm a citizen of the Great Nation who carries an identity tag because I judged him wrongly.”

“Hm. You talk like you belong to the authorities.”

“Something like that, but not quite.”

“That’s vague. Care to give me an example?”

“You don’t need to know.”

“Oh.”

At the calm, cold answer, the young man shrugged and dropped something he’d been holding.

Tap.

A faint sound, and a copper badge flashed as it caught the light. Three characters were engraved on its dirt-streaked surface.

Embroidered Uniform Guard.

“Whoops. Dropped it by accident. I was going to keep it as a souvenir.”

His voice was exaggerated, but his gaze, fixed on Commander Jeong, had settled into a deep stillness.

“I was only looking for the flask, but this weird thing came out with it.”

“You’ve got sticky fingers for a rogue of the martial world.”

“Let’s call it self-defense. If it had been the person I serve, this wouldn’t have ended with just that.”

Commander Jeong raised a hand instead of answering.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard drew their weapons and surrounded the young man in a wave of steel.

“Before I kill you, I’ll ask one thing.”

“If you have time, ask as many as you like. I’d like to live a little longer, if possible.”

Something flickered in Commander Jeong’s eyes.

This unexpected encounter was as good as over. At his signal, the young man would die in an instant, and they would continue on their way as though nothing had happened.

And yet…

He has no intention of backing down.

The young man feared death, but he would not retreat. Commander Jeong saw the spirit of a martial artist in him.

“What is your name?”

“Hyuk Mujin.”

Commander Jeong nodded to Hyuk Mujin.

“Who’s behind this?”

None of this was a coincidence.

Someone whose identity they didn’t know had been waiting for them from the start. They had surely placed people at every chokepoint the procession had to pass through.

Commander Jeong needed to learn who it was. The answer came from somewhere he never expected.

“Being called the one behind it sounds a little grand, but now that I hear it, I kind of like it. Makes me feel like a Constellation.[3314]”

There had been no sound. No trace of a presence.

Yet the shadow of a young man had appeared among them, stretching down from a tree above.

“We finally meet. How’ve you been?”

“Do you… know me?”

At Commander Jeong’s stiff question, the young man laughed.

“How the fuck would I know you, you son of a bitch?”

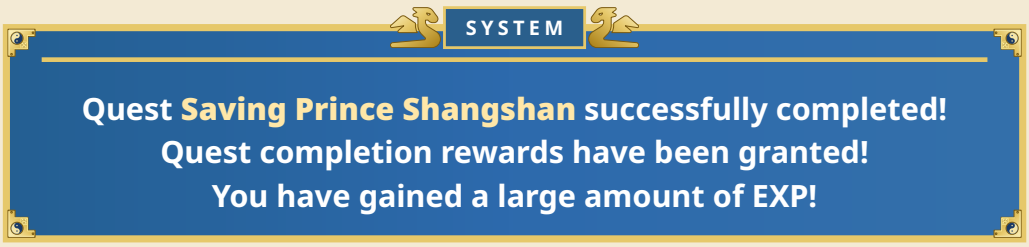
[3314] In Korean fantasy web fiction, a Constellation is often a powerful being who watches over or sponsors others.

Chapter 858

Times like this, I really missed the System.

If it weren't for that damn update, a holographic window would've appeared by now with its signature clear chime.

Ding.



Something like that.

But unlike the scene I'd just imagined, reality was quiet. The cold killing intent pouring from dozens of Embroidered Uniform Guard members pricked my entire body like needles.

"That's enough. Rein it in and put it away. Keep this up and you'll put me in a bad mood."

I tossed out a few words, then pushed off a branch and dropped toward the ground.

No—I walked down through empty air, stepping on it as if it were a staircase.

"Stepping on Empty Air…!"

Someone's gasp reached my ears. I could almost feel the Embroidered Uniform Guard's blade-sharp aura waver.

It burns through internal energy like crazy, but nothing beats it for this.

No matter how hostile someone was, after seeing something like that, they wouldn't dare bare their teeth at me.

Stepping on Empty Air was a technique exclusive to Supreme Peak masters.

Tap.

I landed lightly on the ground. Waiting for me there was a beast howling miserably.

"Waaah, Captain!"

"Stop. Don't come over here. Shut up."

"Where have you been all this time?! I was so scared!"

"…"

I'd gone to all that trouble to set the mood, and this bastard—

I let out a deep sigh and pushed Hyuk Mujin away as he kept trying to hug me.

"Ah, quit whining. I didn't leave you behind."

“What?”

“I just took a nap up there. I was tired.”

We’d been on a forced march for over ten days.

Even with three jiazi[3315] of internal energy and a body beyond human limits, I couldn’t beat the need for sleep. The fact that I’d held out this long was practically a miracle.

Scouting and standing night watch in case something happened. Checking on the others and looking after them. And on top of that, the mental strain.

If the Divine Physician hadn’t tried to stop me and Jeok Cheongang hadn’t helped, I might have collapsed before we ever reached Jiangsu.

I wasn’t exactly in good shape, either. I’d been sleeping for half a shichen[3316] every three days.

After going through all that hell, it was only natural that sleep hit me the moment we reached our destination and I was sure we’d arrived ahead of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

“…So you slept? In a tree?”

“Yeah. If I slept on the road, my mouth would get crooked. And I might get attacked while I was out cold.”

“What about me?”

“You? What about you?”

“I’m asking why you threw me down in the middle of the road while you went somewhere safe to sleep by yourself.”

“Someone had to keep watch on the road. And I didn’t throw you.”

“Then what did you do?”

“I set you down. Carefully.”

I’d actually more or less tossed him down. I was that tired.

Hyuk Mujin’s mouth fell open at my slightly dishonest answer.

“So it doesn’t matter if my mouth goes crooked?”

“You’re the kind of man who speaks the truth even with a crooked mouth. That’s Hyuk Mujin.”

“You said we could be attacked!”

“And I’d wake up when I heard it. Like I did just now.”

“I almost died! If you’d woken up moments later, I’d have been a dead man!”

“But I woke up moments earlier. You’re alive.”

“My God. Captain, are you even human?”

I wasn’t sure what gave the bastard who’d been snoring on my back the right to say that, but I decided to show him a little mercy and let it slide.

[3315] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle; three jiazi equal 180 years.

[3316] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

We'd been pushing ourselves hard, and besides…

The way he'd looked a little while ago had been pretty impressive.

"Good job."

At my sudden praise, Hyuk Mujin furrowed his brow.

"What?"

"I said you did a good job. Holding on even in a situation like that."

"…!"

"But don't do that again. If you think you can't win, take a step back and think of another way."

I patted Hyuk Mujin on the shoulder, then slowly turned around and added,

"Right, Your Excellency from the Embroidered Uniform Guard?"

Our eyes met in midair.

His eyes were impassive, showing no particular emotion. Unlike the others, the man at the head of the procession hadn't so much as blinked at my appearance. He spoke.

"You know that, and yet you blocked our way. Reckless, to say the least."

"Mister, watch your mouth. I've still got plenty of hair."

"I don't know what nonsense you're talking about, but you are standing against the Embroidered Uniform Guard, who are carrying out the Emperor's command. Do you understand that?"

"Of course I do."

"I see. So you admit to treason."

Treason?

Could it really be called that?

After a moment's thought, I decided I ought to take back what I'd said.

"Uh. Then I retract what I said earlier."

"…?"

"I was walking along, got tired, and took a nap. And then, by coincidence, you happened to pass by. How's that?"

Hyuk Mujin, who'd been looking at me as though my earlier praise had touched him a little, answered quickly.

"Sounds fine to me."

"Right?"

"Yes. It's convincing. Plenty of people sleep rough while traveling."

"You know what you're talking about. What can they do if it was a coincidence?"

"Exactly. Jiangsu isn't their land."

"Wait. Isn't it, though? Jiangsu or anywhere else, it's all part of the Great Nation."

"Huh. Does it work like that?"

“Doesn’t it? That’s what I understand.”

“Captain, since when do you know things like that?”

“You little shit.”

“Sorry. Anyway, I’ll remember that and ask Old Man Nam later… Hey, where is everybody?”

Just as I was about to answer, the man spoke first.

“What is the meaning of this?”

“Oh, sorry. We got sidetracked for a second. Anyway, now that you mention it, Jiangsu belongs to you lot too, right?”

“All the mountains and rivers under heaven are ruled by His Imperial Majesty, whose authority is—no, why am I even answering this?”

“It’s nice to help each other out.”

“Enough!”

Our frantic conversation seemed to have rattled him.

I narrowed my eyes at the man, whose aura had grown as cold as frost.

“You there, Your Excellency from the Embroidered Uniform Guard. You said you were Thousand Captain Jeong, right? Why be so stiff about this? Frankly, neither of us stands to gain anything by fighting here.”

Shing.

A cold blade appeared in place of an answer. Thousand Captain Jeong drew the enormous saber from his back and spoke in a rigid voice.

“It makes no difference who you are. The Embroidered Uniform Guard obeys His Imperial Majesty. If you oppose his command and stand in our way, you will die.”

Fwooooooosh.

An invisible force spread out from him. I licked my dry lips as I felt his aura—pure and heavy.

Well, look at that…

I’d suspected it from the moment I first saw him, but the man called Thousand Captain Jeong was a formidable master.

No—by ordinary standards, even “formidable” was an understatement. His skill was enough to shatter a prejudice I’d held deep inside.

He doesn’t seem to have crossed the Supreme Peak threshold yet, but he’s at least at the very top of Peak.

The authorities and Murim were always close and yet far apart.

Murim was one forest within the Great Nation’s borders, but that forest was full of beasts like dragons and tigers.

And yet, even among those serving the authorities, I’d rarely seen a proper master.

Common soldiers were Third Rate or Second Rate, while martial officers were First Rate at best. Peak masters were rare among those in the military.

And most of those had belonged to Murim before.

The former Captain of the Guards to the City Lord of Sichuan Province had been a famous wandering martial artist, practically a personal bodyguard. Li Feng, Assistant Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province, was a former lay disciple of Huashan who'd joined the military after passing the military examination.

But…

Where'd a master of his caliber come from?

My experience might not have been all that broad, but as a Supreme Peak master, I could get a rough measure of someone's ability at a glance.

And Thousand Captain Jeong bore not the slightest trace of a Murim martial artist. From head to toe, he looked every inch a general.

Even his internal energy is pure.

What was more surprising was that the other Embroidered Uniform Guard members were no exception.

They ranged from young men who looked to be in their twenties to middle-aged men around forty. They varied in skill, but it wasn't hard to tell that most of them were Peak masters.

Dozens of Peak masters…

A force to match a mid-sized sect—or surpass one.

Whether they lived up to their reputation as the Son of Heaven's hands and feet, or had been trained by someone other than the Son of Heaven, was a question for later.

I had no intention of letting this standoff continue when neither side stood to gain anything.

"Impressive aura, but you'd better put away those ugly weapons before someone gets hurt."

The instant I stepped forward after warning them—

Whoosh!

A shaft of light shot straight at my face with a powerful crack of air. I caught it as gently as if I were cradling it, then sent it flying back the way it had come.

Thud! Boom!

Instead of a final scream, a tremor rolled through the ground.

The archer, who'd leapt from the saddle of his fallen steed, stared at me in disbelief. An arrow was lodged in the center of the horse's forehead.

"I told you to put away what you were holding."

"…!"

"You're the reason it died, you animal-abusing bastard."

Hyuk Mujin, scratching his grime-covered body as if he'd known this was coming, said, "Why is it his fault? You're the one who killed it, Captain."

“If we’re getting technical, sure. But Mujin.”

“Yes?”

“I can kill you too.”

“I’m sorry. I spoke out of turn.”

“All right, got it.”

It was a peaceful conversation, as usual. But the tension around us had already grown so taut it felt ready to burst.

Snort. Snort.

Dozens of horses breathed heavily. The hands gripping their reins with all their strength had gone white, and the aura pouring from their riders wavered but didn’t subside.

At their head stood Thousand Captain Jeong.

“You’re crossing a river that should never be crossed.”

“I haven’t crossed it yet. But setting that aside, you all seem pretty confident. No matter how good you are, you won’t come out of a fight with me looking pretty.”

“What I and these men place our faith in is not our personal martial skill. It is our loyalty as subjects who carry out His Imperial Majesty’s command.”

“What’s your name?”

“Jeong Hogun.”

Thousand Captain Jeong—Jeong Hogun—had given me his name much more readily than I expected. Then he asked in return,

“And yours?”

“Jin Taekyung.”

I wasn’t the one who gave that answer.

Jeong Hogun and I both turned our heads. Then we both dropped to one knee and bowed.

Step.

Beneath my lowered gaze, someone’s foot came into view—much larger than it had been in the last glimpse I remembered.

With it came a voice that had grown more mature, too. No longer the voice of a little child.

“It’s been a long time, Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

The bloodline of a dragon, grown so much taller, helped me to my feet.

And before I could even answer, he handed me something he’d been holding.

This is…

A secret letter.

The moment that secretive word pierced my mind, Prince Shangshan leaned close to my ear and whispered,

“Please give me your autograph.”

“…”

No, Your Highness. What the fuck.

Chapter 859

“Pardon me, but may I say something?”

Jeong Hogun answered calmly as one of his subordinates rode beside him.

“If you think what you have to say is out of line, don’t say it in the first place.”

“Thousand Captain!”

The subordinate’s gaze was deeply troubled, his expression stiff.

He’d shared hardship with Jeong Hogun for more than ten years. Jeong Hogun already knew what he was going to say without hearing it.

“I can guess well enough how you feel. You’re unhappy with this situation.”

“Unhappy doesn’t begin to cover it. Are you really going to stand by and let those rogues carry on like this?”

The subordinate glared over his shoulder at the slowly moving carriage.

Laughter and conversation streamed through a window left slightly ajar. His expression hardened, as did those of the Embroidered Uniform Guard around him.

“It’s not too late. If you’ll just give the order…”

He let his voice trail off, but Jeong Hogun understood exactly what he meant.

“You want to start a bloodbath?”

“I understand your concerns, Thousand Captain. But we can’t just let a band of traitors who defy the Emperor’s supreme command go free.”

“And if we don’t leave them alone, are you confident you can bring that man down?”

“Well…”

The subordinate was suddenly at a loss for words.

Though he served in the military, he was a martial artist who had trained in martial arts himself. The thought of the man laughing and chatting inside the carriage right now made it hard to answer.

Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

No—Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

I’d heard he was still young, but I never imagined he’d be that strong.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard received reports from every corner of the land. But stories about the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon were so well known that the subordinate had heard plenty even without relying on their far-flung spies.

A descendant of a fallen martial family.

The heir to the Fire Gate Clan, passed down through a single successor for more than three hundred years.

The troublemaker nobody in Shanxi had failed to hear of had become a Divine Dragon in barely two years. Now he stood at the heart of the turbulent currents shaking Murim.

But there was only one reason Jin Taekyung had become so exceptional.

His martial might.

Everything had its limits, martial arts included. But Jin Taekyung had already soared far beyond them. It was no wonder he was called one of the Two Dragons alongside Cheongpung, the Huashan Divine Dragon, and hailed as a talent unseen in a thousand years.

Nor was it surprising that, after a long silence, Jeong Hogun's subordinate answered:

"Much as I hate to admit it… as things stand, we'd have a hard time facing him."

"If you know that, that's enough."

Jeong Hogun replied evenly. For the Embroidered Uniform Guard, who served the Emperor's solemn command, it was a humiliating conclusion. But as a soldier, it was the right one.

A soldier had to be clear-eyed about victory and defeat. Let pride lead him to the wrong decision, and he would never win the battle.

Even so, there was one thing the Embroidered Uniform Guard could never do: submit or retreat before an opponent, no matter how powerful.

"I know how you feel. All of you."

Jeong Hogun continued in a low voice.

"But the Emperor's command was to escort His Highness Prince Shangshan to the Imperial Capital. As discreetly as possible, without causing the slightest disturbance."

"…"

"If His Highness Prince Shangshan hadn't ordered us to lower our swords, I would have fought them myself."

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao's actions, however, had stunned every member of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

This young prince of noble imperial blood had personally helped a rogue of the martial world to his feet. As if that weren't enough, he'd asked the rogue to sign the silver token he carried.

"What's done is done. This matter isn't ours to decide. Don't speak of it again."

His voice allowed no argument. The subordinate pressed his lips together.

Jeong Hogun was right. Their duty was to escort Prince Shangshan to the Imperial Capital. Loyalty to the Son of Heaven was one thing; authority was another.

Jeong Hogun spoke again to the subordinate struggling to contain his displeasure. This time, he used Sound Transmission so that only the man could hear him.

—I have something for you to do.

The subordinate stared at him with wide eyes, then moved his lips.

—Give me your orders.

—Go to the Commander-in-Chief in the Imperial Capital. You, personally.

—To the Commander-in-Chief?

The Commander-in-Chief was the head of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Among the high-ranking officials packed into the Imperial Capital, where all manner of powerful figures gathered, the Commander-in-Chief of the Embroidered Uniform Guard held exceptional influence and authority. And his immense power came from one person alone.

—You mean…

The subordinate didn't finish his sentence, but both men knew whose rank his words implied.

The Son of Heaven.

Ruler of this vast continent.

A giant seated on the throne, looking down upon countless officials and subjects.

The reason the Embroidered Uniform Guard existed, and the one to whom they pledged absolute loyalty.

So Jeong Hogun's order to inform the Commander-in-Chief was no different from telling him to report directly to the Son of Heaven.

—Thousand Captain… what would you have me do?

—Leave at once. Go straight to the Commander-in-Chief and tell him this.

Jeong Hogun continued his Sound Transmission slowly.

—Just as you predicted, uninvited guests have interfered.

—…!

—Go. I won't be going far.

The subordinate stared at Jeong Hogun, eyes wide with disbelief. Then a faint smile crossed his lips.

A prediction. He'd definitely called it a prediction.

Those two words were enough. His displeasure with his superior, who had seemed so unlike himself, and the Embroidered Uniform Guard's wounded pride both vanished completely.

—Loyalty!

The subordinate gave a vigorous military salute he could not accompany with a shout, then rode off like the wind, moving as one with his horse.

Jeong Hogun watched him disappear and thought to himself:

Everything was in the palm of the Embroidered Uniform Guard—or rather, of His Imperial Majesty, the Son of Heaven.

Just as it always had been.

Senses were like vision.

Just as looking at what was in front of you didn't erase the scenery around you, I took in every bit of information from all directions with my keen senses, even as I talked.

The small movements of birds bounding through the thick undergrowth.

The chill surrounding the Embroidered Uniform Guard as they encircled the carriage—as though escorting it. Or besieging it.

And…

The sound of a horse's hooves rapidly fading into the distance.

"I've continued to hear news of you. Every time I hear another of those unbelievable tales of your exploits, my heart swells."

"If you're hyperventilating, that's a little concerning. I happen to know a good physician. Why don't you get a checkup while you're at it, Your Highness?"

"I'm glad you're concerned for me. But entrusting my health to a physician I don't even know would go against imperial etiquette. Once we reach the Imperial Capital, there will be an Imperial Physician, so…"

"Then I guess there's no choice. The Divine Physician is exhausted, too, so that's probably for the best."

"Wait. Who did you say?"

"The Divine Physician."

"I'll see him! I absolutely will!"

"What about imperial etiquette?"

"Rules are there to be broken."

No matter how noble his blood, he was still a child.

I humored Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao as he chattered away, his face flushed, and sent a Sound Transmission to Hong Jin, whom I could see over the prince's shoulder.

—They've sent someone off. But I really don't think he's a scout.

Hong Jin had learned martial arts, but hadn't reached the Peak realm. Instead of answering with Sound Transmission, he nodded quietly, mindful of the Embroidered Uniform Guard surrounding the carriage.

—He must've gone to deliver a message. Any idea where?

Maybe he'd been reading fan wikis or something; while Zhu Bao rambled on about the Divine Physician, Hong Jin used a finger as a brush and wrote in the air.

The Imperial Capital.

It wasn't good news, but I'd expected as much.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard had been created by the Great Nation's Emperor to serve as his own hands and feet. Anything concerning Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao was certain to reach the Emperor's ears.

The Imperial Capital, huh…

I liked peaches.[3317]

But in Murim, the Imperial Capital was the center of the world.

Or rather, that was what the Emperor's position made it.

He ruled the people of this vast land. Wherever the Son of Heaven resided was the center of the world, the dragon's den.

Though in this case, it's a tiger's den.

I'd never been to the Imperial Capital, but I'd heard about it often enough.

Enormous buildings that seemed to pierce the sky. Beautiful historic sites that made visitors gasp in awe. Wealth pouring in along its canals.

Add fertile land and abundant supplies, and it was a paradise on earth, second to none.

Except for one thing.

The million Imperial Guards protecting the Son of Heaven and the Imperial Capital.

Not ten thousand. Not a hundred thousand.

A million.

Even if I allowed for the usual exaggeration from the people of this continent and cut that figure in half, there'd still be an army of more than five hundred thousand lurking around Zhejiang Province, where the Imperial Capital stood.

That many… Fuck, I can't even picture it.

I licked my parched lips without realizing it.

I really didn't want to be acting like this, but I couldn't shake the ominous feeling that had haunted me ever since Sichuan.

What if my suspicion is right, and the Emperor has some sort of relationship with Dark Heaven?

I didn't need to think about the answer.

We'd be fucked. Simple as that.

The moment we entered the Imperial Capital, surrounded by layers upon layers of a million Imperial Guards, it would all be over.

If the Son of Heaven, who was as good as a living god, gave the order, countless blades would come flying at us from every direction. He wouldn't even have to say much. He'd just point at us and say one thing:

"They're dangerous traitors."

"…"

[3317] In Korean, *hwangdo* means both "Imperial Capital" and "yellow peach."

Just imagining it made my knees go weak.

I'd fallen silent. Hyuk Mujin, huddled in a corner of the carriage, asked cautiously, "Why do you look like you've got a mouthful of shit?"

"…Mujin."

"Yes, Captain."

"You're always so careful with your tone. Why is what you actually say so damn bold?"

"Because I'm the manliest of men. Hyuk Mujin, the Tenfold Man—man enough for ten men! That's me."

"…"

Is this guy actually insane?

I was silently cursing Hyuk Mujin with my eyes when Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, who had stopped talking to listen to us, let out a quiet gasp.

"The Tenfold Man? An extraordinary title. Just what I'd expect from your subordinate."

"…?"

"…?"

"It must be fate that we've met. You said your name was Hyuk Mujin, the Tenfold Man?"

Hyuk Mujin blinked, then hurriedly bowed his head.

"Y-Yes, Your Highness Prince Shangshan. But I'm sorry to say my title isn't the Tenfold Man…"

"Here. Sign this."

"Pardon?"

"No need to refuse, Hyuk Mujin, the Tenfold Man. This shall be an honor passed down through your family for generations."

"…"

"…"

Hyuk Mujin took the bronze token Zhu Bao handed him and inscribed his new title on it.

Watching him, I thought:

What a fucking mess. Seriously.

Chapter 860

Murim martial artists were like weeds.

You found them in dark back alleys and on bright main streets. They survived in the depths of the mountains and even out on the vast Yangtze.

Perhaps that was why the world they lived in came to be called Murim—the forest of martial arts.

Ruffians who ignored common sense and the law.

But even among the Murim martial artists who had carved out a forest of their own with sharply honed spears and blades, not all of them could grow into towering trees.

In the vast forest of Murim, only the Nine Sects and One Gang, the Five Great Families, and a few other forces that had established themselves as rulers of a province could claim that distinction. And those few hadn't yet reached the heights of the great sects and families.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan is one of them, too.

I thought to myself as I looked out the window.

Merchants hawking their wares. A woodcutter passing by, sweating buckets under a full load of firewood. Ordinary commoners and dignitaries dressed in silk.

All sorts of people were out there, making up a society. But one particular sort I'd seen almost everywhere until now was hard to spot.

"You can't find any, can you?"

"Pardon?"

"Murim martial artists. Ones like Young Master Jin."

Hong Jin had read my thoughts exactly. A smile spread across his powder-white face.

"I thought I'd tell you before you waste your energy looking. They're hard to find in Jiangsu Province. That's just the kind of place this is."

"I've heard something to that effect… Is it because we're so close to the imperial capital?"

"That must be part of it. They can't let those ruffians run wild near the imperial capital, where the Son of Heaven resides."

Hong Jin glanced at Hyuk Mujin and me, then added, "Just so you don't misunderstand, that's how the people at the top see it. The higher up they are, the more they care about appearances."

It sounded like he was saying that to keep me from taking offense, but he didn't need to. I could see the reasoning.

Well, to be precise, there were plenty of Murim martial artists who went too far.

But proximity to the imperial capital couldn't explain everything. Hyuk Mujin's next question was along the same lines.

"Then what about the Namgung Family, sitting right there in Anhui? They're not all that far from the imperial capital, either."

"Before I answer that, let me ask you the reverse. What's left among the provinces next to the imperial capital, apart from the Namgung Family in Anhui?"

"Apart from the Namgung Family… Well, there's…"

Hyuk Mujin struggled to finish, and Hong Jin let out a quiet chuckle.

"Nothing. Jiangxi, Fujian, Jiangsu, and Anhui. Of the four provinces surrounding Zhejiang, where the imperial capital stands, the Namgung Family is the only famous Murim sect. There are exceptions, of course."

"Exceptions?"

"Yeah. How should I put it? Judging by its history, it sounds like it ought to be dangerous, but the imperial court would feel uneasy about going out of its way to provoke it. Can you think of a sect like that, Martial artist Hyuk?"

Hyuk Mujin frowned in thought.

"If I went looking, I could probably find a few sects. But is there really one like that? Compared to the Namgung Family in Anhui, they'd be worth less than a horse's balls."

"Martial artist Hyuk, I don't have any balls."

"Ah! I'm sorry."

"No, you don't need to apologize that much. It just felt strange hearing it. Anyway, you really can't think of one?"

"No. Of course not."

Just then, I smacked Hyuk Mujin on the back of the head, the idiot who'd answered so confidently.

Whack!

"The Fire Gate Clan, you asshole! The Fire Gate Clan!"

"Ugh! Ow!"

"Mount Jiuhua in Anhui Province! Three hundred years of history! You saying the Fire Gate Clan's worth less than a horse's balls? You think the Fire Gate Clan's a bunch of fucking pushovers?"

For the record, I was in my second year with the Fire Gate Clan and diligently working my way through the heir-apparent training program.

As I beat Hyuk Mujin with my burning love for the company as fuel, Hong Jin spoke quietly.

"Um, Young Master Jin, sorry, but…"

"Oh, sorry. You don't have those either."

"That's not what I meant. I was worried His Highness would wake up. And being a eunuch doesn't mean both are gone. I think I told you that before."

"My apologies again. I forgot you were only missing one."

"…All right. Just be careful, please. And keep your voice down so His Highness doesn't wake."

Looking half resigned, Hong Jin glanced at Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, who was sleeping peacefully, and went on.

"Anyway, Murim martial artists haven't been able to run wild in the provinces bordering the imperial capital, not just Zhejiang. That goes for followers of demonic, heterodox arts, of course. Even the Namgung Family—a towering tree of the orthodox faction and one of the Five Great Families—had to call on every connection it had among high-ranking officials."

"It was that bad?"

"Yes. It started right after the Great Nation was founded, so we're talking about a long time ago. But things have stayed that way ever since. No matter how rough Murim martial artists are, I doubt they want to meet the same fate as the Maoshan Sect."

"The Maoshan Sect?"

The name sounded familiar. It had come up now and then in the wuxia[3318] novels I'd loved reading back in school.

It wasn't a major sect like the Nine Sects and One Gang, which appeared in practically every novel. More of a minor one. Still, I could remember a few things about it.

Come to think of it…

"You mean the Maoshan Sect famous for sorcery rather than martial arts?"

"Hm? You didn't know? It used to be right here in Jiangsu Province."

It wasn't as if I were some old master like the Fire King, who'd lived for over a hundred years. How was I supposed to know everything that had happened when the Great Nation was founded?

But I'd caught something in what Hong Jin said.

Used to be in Jiangsu Province…

Past tense, not present. He'd also mentioned the Maoshan Sect's fate, and I'd never once heard its name during my time in Murim. The pieces fell into place.

"It disappeared. A long time ago."

"Correct."

Hong Jin snapped his fingers cheerfully.

[3318] Wuxia is Chinese fiction about martial heroes, commonly set in a historical martial world.

“When Taizu founded the Great Nation, he chose this region for his capital. Nanjing, in Jiangsu Province, had been the seat of six dynasties. It became the imperial family’s first home.”

“So what happened?”

“With a new unified dynasty on the rise, could they really let the ruffians of the martial world run wild? Once the imperial edict went out, everything moved at lightning speed. Most of the sects in Jiangsu Province moved elsewhere. You’re starting to see where this is going, aren’t you?”

Most of the sects, not all of them.

Guessing what came next, I murmured, “The Maoshan Sect didn’t.”

“Right. A small number of Murim sects, including the Maoshan Sect, refused the imperial order to leave Jiangsu and held on to their headquarters. They say the Maoshan Sect was big enough to rival the Nine Sects and One Gang back then, so it could afford to be stubborn. But…”

The Great Nation’s first emperor had risen from the dirt and opened a new era—but he hadn’t been as magnanimous as the Maoshan Sect had thought.

“According to the surviving records, a hundred thousand Imperial Guards were dispatched. They killed and burned everything. They didn’t leave behind a single blade of grass or even an ant.”

“…!”

“…!”

“That was how the Maoshan Sect was wiped out. Afterward, no Murim sect established itself in Jiangsu again. Not even after the current Son of Heaven moved the capital to Zhejiang.”

Jiangsu wasn’t merely the site of the old imperial capital.

It was a Murim-free zone the Imperial Guards had already swept clean, the imperial family’s front yard, still steeped in the first emperor’s legacy.

And what that meant for us was clear.

We can forget about asking for help.

Until now, we’d been able to find help almost anywhere. Every province had a sect or two that had put down roots there, and most of them were friendly toward Jeok Cheongang or the Murim Alliance.

That had held true even in Nanman, practically the middle of nowhere, and on our recent journey, when we’d had no choice but to charge straight ahead.

The Nanman Beast Palace had old ties with the Fire Gate Clan. The Beggars’ Sect and the Lower District Sect, both under the Murim Alliance, had prepared food or fine horses at stops along our route to Jiangsu.

But not from here on out.

If Jiangsu, the old imperial capital, was like this, what would Zhejiang, home to the current capital, be like?

Completely Murim-free. Maybe the odd neighborhood martial arts school.

If the worst happened, what we'd need most was fighting strength. And there wouldn't be a group with the strength I wanted anywhere nearby.

Forget the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families. We were down to a neighborhood Taekwondo[3319] school.

No, I guess it would be a tai chi[3320] school here.

Just picturing a crowd in colorful matching uniforms rushing to our aid made me dizzy.

"We've come to help!"

"What sect are you from?"

"Kyunghee Tai Chi!"

"Oh, I see… If you don't mind me asking, how far along are you in your martial arts?"

"I'm a black belt!"

"Ah…"

"The Zhejiang Kendo[3321] Association is here, too!"

"Ahhh…"

I could only hope they weren't from the kids' class.

It was bad enough to fall for that bait-and-switch pitch: sign up for the martial arts school and get three million mesos[3322]—no, three taels[3323] in iron coins. If those kids wound up facing the Imperial Guards too, how could I ever look their parents in the eye?

"At least let it be the adult class. The afternoon adult class…"

"Young Master Jin. Young Master Jin?"

I'd been muttering in a daze, but Hong Jin's call snapped me back to my senses.

"Ah."

"Are you all right?"

"Yes. I'm fine."

"Really? You're sweating like it's pouring rain."

"I had a bad thought for a moment."

Hong Jin's face darkened.

"I'm starting to feel bad for calling you here. But I couldn't help it. You were the only person I could think of."

"No. I understand."

[3319] Taekwondo is a Korean martial art known especially for its kicks.

[3320] Tai chi is a Chinese martial art often practiced through slow, flowing movements.

[3321] Kendo is a Japanese martial art of swordsmanship.

[3322] Mesos are the in-game currency of *MapleStory*.

[3323] A tael is a traditional East Asian unit of weight also used to reckon money; its value varied by place and era.

If Hong Jin had only needed someone he could trust, he could have asked the nearby Jin Family of Taiyuan for support.

But, to be blunt, there was no one in the family as strong as me.

No—someone who met all his requirements would be hard to find anywhere under heaven.

Hong Jin didn't just want someone he trusted. He wanted someone strong enough to save Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao from any threat.

There's the Murim Alliance, but moving another Supreme Peak master Hong Jin could trust on such short notice would've been too risky.

Even moving a rock on the beach left a mark.

The Alliance had probably already stationed forces across the land in preparation for a battle with Dark Heaven. Pulling out a Supreme Peak master would leave an enormous gap.

Given the stakes and the timing, Jeok Cheongang and I, having just finished our mission in Nanman, were probably the most dependable people Hong Jin could have called on.

This could eat away at the very foundations of the nation.

I kept that thought to myself. Then a voice I still couldn't get used to, no matter how often I heard it, came from outside the window.

"We'll reach Suzhou soon."

The voice was as hard as stone. Jeong Hogun, a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, looked at me through the gap in the window.

"Inform His Highness Prince Shangshan. He will have an audience with His Imperial Majesty before the day is out."

Chapter 861

Jeong Hogun hadn’t been lying when he said they would reach the imperial capital that day.

The procession passed through Nanjing, the capital of Jiangsu Province and the former imperial capital, and finally arrived in Suzhou. At the border with Zhejiang Province, they encountered a force of soldiers.

“We’ve been waiting for you, Thousand Captain.”

Eyes gleamed beneath helmets and suits of iron armor that covered every inch of their bodies.

Each man radiated a heavy aura. There were nearly a thousand of them, and on the golden banners fluttering in the wind, the dragon that symbolized the imperial family writhed as if alive.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard.

These loyal hounds, who answered to only one person in the world—the Son of Heaven—saluted their superior, Jeong Hogun, then faced the young prince who carried the noble blood of the imperial family.

“His Highness Prince Shangshan is here. Pay your respects.”

“Long live the prince! Long live the prince! Long, long live the prince!”

Watching the Embroidered Uniform Guard shout in unison without even dismounting, Hong Jin found himself wondering:

How many of them truly meant it?

No—was there even one?

Hong Jin already knew the answer. He swallowed a bitter smile.

They and I are nothing more than beasts. What matters is the will of the master who raises those beasts.

The Son of Heaven stood above all others. He could decide who lived and who died.

Nothing could stand in the way of his will.

Not even the blade that had narrowly missed the young prince amid that terrible purge more than a decade ago.

Nor this carriage, now heading toward the Son of Heaven’s returning blade.

“Pick up the pace. The imperial capital is just ahead.”

As the sun began to sink, the carriage raced like the wind.

Jeong Hogun and the Embroidered Uniform Guard under his command had hidden their identities in worn martial clothes for thousands of li.[3324] Now they wore dazzling brocade and armor befitting their name, advancing like a wave beneath imperial banners held high.

[3324] A Chinese li is a unit of distance equal to 500 meters, or about 0.311 miles.

Like victors returning with an enemy general in chains.

“Make way!”

Nothing could stand in the way of a thousand members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

The commoners prostrated themselves, fear and awe mingling in their eyes, as the procession with the young prince at its head passed through the gates flung wide before them.

In just half a day, they traveled along roads and waterways cleared for them alone. At last, Hong Jin saw it.

The massive wall he’d thought he would never see again in his lifetime. The wall he had sworn never to return to, if only for the sake of the young prince he served.

The imperial capital…!

Hong Jin forced down the sigh that nearly escaped him.

He could see what lay out of sight. He could hear what no longer made a sound.

The dragon’s lair crouched behind those towering walls. The countless screams that had echoed endlessly around a single throne.

They were horrific fragments of the past, lodged deep in Hong Jin’s mind—and the history that had made one man the ruler of the continent.

“I’ll spare you. Just this once.”

At the sudden memory of someone’s cold voice ringing in his ears, Hong Jin clenched his teeth without realizing it.

It won’t go as Your Majesty wishes. Not this time.

The sunset spreading from the distant west stained the walls of the imperial capital.

Hangzhou made a fine first impression.

It had an abundance of goods carried by canal throughout Zhejiang Province, and its scenery was beautiful.

The broad plains we’d passed on the way were covered in all kinds of grain, rippling like golden waves. Smiles never left the people’s faces.

They say it’s the most beautiful city under heaven.

I’d heard that once in passing. It was absolutely true.

Maybe that was why they’d abandoned a great city with Nanjing’s long history and moved the capital to Hangzhou.

There was just one problem: this beautiful city felt a lot more ominous than I’d expected.

Clank. Clank.

The cold scrape of blades.

Whichever way I turned, I saw soldiers. Not the half-trained grunts I was used to, either—these were fully armed elite troops.

Even the easygoing Hyuk Mujin had lost his smile.

"Captain. This is a bit… much, isn't it?"

Normally, I'd have shot back at him out of habit. This time, even I had to agree.

Why are there so many?

There weren't just a lot of them. There were a downright disgusting number.

I was starting to wonder if Zhejiang Province's specialty wasn't Longjing tea but Imperial Guards.

"Is security always this tight?"

Hyuk Mujin wasn't the only one who'd lost his smile after we entered Hangzhou.

Hong Jin answered in a voice so stiff it hardly sounded like him.

"As the imperial capital, it's always well guarded. But it's never been like this before."

"Then…"

"They must have received some sort of order. And it's probably… connected to us somehow."

Hong Jin licked his red-painted lips and murmured,

"I'd expected something, but this is more of a welcome than I bargained for."

For a moment, I pictured a hundred thousand soldiers pointing their spears and blades at us. Then I shook my head.

That's unlikely.

If they'd wanted to kill Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao that easily, he wouldn't have made it out of Shanxi Province.

I didn't know exactly why the Son of Heaven had sent the Embroidered Uniform Guard to bring his younger brother here. But one thing was certain: whatever he did with Prince Shangshan, it would be something he could publicly justify.

That was the nature of an emperor.

Besides, his public image is already bad.

There was a reason people said the people's will was the will of Heaven.

The nomadic people of the steppe, who had ruled the continent before the Great Nation, had fallen as the people's support crumbled.

The emperor ruled the people, but without the people, there could be no emperor.

And the public's view of the current Son of Heaven was far from favorable.

A capable but ruthless emperor.

I'd heard that description now and then in Murim. Quiet conversations with Hong Jin on the way here had filled in the details.

From a young age, the current emperor had built an impressive military record putting down rebellions and uprisings by foreign peoples. He was also praised for governing every region placed under his charge without the slightest lapse.

Hong Jin said that if he'd been born the late Emperor's eldest son—or if his eldest brother, the Crown Prince, had been even a little less capable—he would naturally have inherited the throne.

But things hadn't worked out that way.

Before becoming emperor, he'd been nowhere near the line of succession.

He had three older brothers. The eldest had naturally become Crown Prince under the principle of primogeniture, and he was every bit as outstanding as his younger brother—perhaps even more so, depending on whom you asked.

He treated people with benevolence and integrity regardless of their status, and had shown every quality needed to lead the Great Nation.

Hong Jin had described the Crown Prince of that time as:

A Son of Heaven prepared for the throne.

The long wars had ended long ago.

The seeds of rebellion scattered across the land had been uprooted, as had the foreign peoples who had constantly eyed the Great Nation.

The Great Nation had been established on firm foundations. What it needed now wasn't conquest, but stability. With his perfect orthodox lineage and all the qualities a ruler could need, the Crown Prince was a successor prepared in every respect.

Until the imperial family's fourth son, already pushed far from the line of succession, drew his sword from the shadows.

Clip-clop.

The unusually clear sound of hooves snapped me out of my thoughts. I looked around.

Where are we?

The answer came quickly.

The carriage had stopped. Beyond the Embroidered Uniform Guard packed tightly around us stood enormous buildings unlike any I'd seen in Murim.

They were tall enough to remind me of modern skyscrapers, but decorated with an elegance and splendor no skyscraper could match. They could only mean one place.

The imperial palace.

The dragon's lair, and the center that kept the enormous gears of the world turning.

I stared silently at the palace entrance. Even through the narrow gap in the window, the sight was overwhelming. Hong Jin leaned close and whispered, barely above a breath.

"Young Master Jin, I've held off asking until now, but… isn't it time you told me?"

The moment he said it, I knew what he meant.

The others besides Hyuk Mujin and me.

Hong Jin wanted to know where our other helpers were—the ones who still hadn't shown themselves. I already had my answer.

"Don't worry. You'll find out soon enough."

It wasn't the answer he'd hoped for. Hong Jin furrowed his brow slightly, but didn't complain.

I'd traveled all this way without stopping to help them. If we couldn't trust one another in a situation like this, the anxiety and danger would only grow.

And with that in mind, I had a question of my own.

"How do you know so much?"

It was something I'd been wondering for quite some time.

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao might have been a prince in name only, but he was the only direct member of the imperial family to survive the horrific struggle over the throne—and a prince who ruled a fief.

I'd long suspected that Hong Jin, his trusted aide, couldn't be an ordinary eunuch. But how much he knew—and how calmly he dealt with the Embroidered Uniform Guard, feared wherever they went—exceeded even my expectations.

I had to ask him directly, even if it meant doing it like this.

"Since I've risked my life, I deserve an answer to this question. Right now."

Clunk.

Hong Jin stared at me in silence after that firm Sound Transmission. Then, without warning, he flung open the carriage door.

He looked toward a group descending the towering staircase that led from the imperial palace and spoke.

"Young Master Jin, I've told you why I decided to become a eunuch, haven't I?"

I nodded.

Back when Hong Jin and I first met in Shanxi Province, he'd briefly told me about his past.

"I hated being poor, and I wanted to save my family. But I didn't have many options. No—at the time, I only had one."

Hong Jin continued slowly.

To get what you wanted, you had to sacrifice something else.

So the poor boy, unable to bear his hunger, became a eunuch and chose a new name for himself.

“Hong Jin. I wanted to go out into the great waters. To leave that stinking sewer behind for the wide, clear sea.”

It hadn’t taken long for that wish to come true.

The young eunuch had escaped poverty and developed ambitions he’d never had before. He also had the ability to fulfill them.

His unfailing thoroughness and cool judgment soon caught the eye of the late Emperor.

“One day, the late Emperor summoned me. He said there was a place where my abilities could be put to good use.”

Hong Jin’s voice was clear.

“Young Master Jin. Have you ever heard of the East Depot?[3325]”

“…!”

[3325]The East Depot was an imperial secret-police agency in Ming China.

Chapter 862

The East Depot.

Anyone who'd read a few martial arts novels knew that name.

If the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families showed up like clockwork in those stories, then the imperial court had the East Depot, which stood alongside the Embroidered Uniform Guard as its other great power.

And Hong Jin had been a member of that very East Depot.

My mouth fell open before I even realized it.

"The East Depot? The one I'm thinking of?"

"There's only one East Depot in the world, Young Master Jin."

"No, I mean, it actually exists?"

"…Is there a fake East Depot, then?"

"Ah. That's not what I meant."

I hadn't known the East Depot really existed.

It hadn't been that long since I'd learned the Embroidered Uniform Guard was real, either.

The endless incidents and disasters in Murim kept me busy enough. Who would've expected to get tangled up with the imperial court like this?

Still, if Hong Jin came from the East Depot, that would explain a lot about him.

I looked at Hong Jin with fresh astonishment.

I didn't know the details, but the East Depot's influence couldn't be far behind the Embroidered Uniform Guard's.

At first, I'd thought he was just a eunuch who'd been a bit of a tough guy in his youth. Now that I'd heard his story, I could almost picture him hawking up phlegm in the palace corridors.

Hyuk Mujin must have had a similar thought. He glanced sideways at Hong Jin and whispered in a voice barely above a breath.

"Captain. This is no ordinary eunuch."

"…Please, just shut your mouth."

"It's fine. He can't hear me."

"Sorry, but I can hear you just fine."

At Hong Jin's sudden reply, I answered quickly.

"I didn't say anything. That bastard did."

"Gasp. Captain!"

This was no time to go soft. I shook off Hyuk Mujin's hand as he grabbed my sleeve and snapped at him.

“Apologize this instant, you bastard. You’ve got nothing but a pair of balls to your name, and you dare say that?”

“I’m sorry. I’m truly sorry.”

“Beta-male behavior: runs his mouth without thinking, then gets dragged off by the East Depot.”

“I’m sorry! I’ve committed a crime worthy of death!”

“Beta-male behavior: commits a crime worthy of death, then actually dies.”

“No! Please spare me, Comrade Hong! I have tiger-like parents and a rabbit-like younger sibling!”

Whoa, that startled me. For a second, I thought we were in North Korea.

Hyuk Mujin was facedown, wailing like a Communist Party member caught in an ideological purge and dragged off to the Aoji coal mines. Comrade Hong—or rather, Hong Jin, Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province—watched him with a thoroughly unimpressed look and heaved a sigh that seemed to come from the depths of the earth.

“Anyone would think I was the Grim Reaper. Stop making a spectacle of yourself in front of His Highness Prince Shangshan and get up. There are already plenty of eyes on us. At this rate, I’ll die of embarrassment.”

Sadly enough, Hong Jin was right.

The Embroidered Uniform Guards were staring at us as if they couldn’t believe what a bunch of idiots we were. Prince Shangshan, who’d just woken up and was still groggy, opened his eyes wide and asked me,

“Is that man truly known by the sobriquet Tenfold Man?”

I hesitated for a moment, then answered,

“Something like that.”

It wasn’t wrong.

Tenfold Man and Tenfold Beta Man were only one character apart, after all.

Though their meanings are complete opposites.

I held my tongue to protect the young prince’s innocence. Just then, a group came down the endless staircase—long enough to make me wonder if it had been built to torture subjects—and stopped in front of us.

Or, more precisely, they knelt before Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

“We pay our respects to His Highness Prince Shangshan.”

“A thousand years! A thousand years! A thousand thousand years!”

They wore official robes of black silk, but ranged in age from young men who looked barely twenty to old men with deeply wrinkled faces.

Their robes weren’t the only thing they had in common. I realized at once.

Eunuchs.

No doubt about it.

Every one of them had a face powdered white and lips painted red. Their voices sounded neither like women's nor men's, and even their loose robes couldn't hide their small frames.

And yet—

They're strong.

Martial power wasn't decided by the size of your body.

What you saw wasn't everything.

I could feel the immense qi coiled inside their small frames. At the same time, I recalled the name of the organization I'd just heard.

No—I found myself muttering it aloud.

"The East Depot?"

Rustle.

A long hem brushed the ground.

At the head of the eunuchs, an old man who'd bowed deeply to Prince Shangshan raised his head and looked at me.

His strange gaze gave nothing away.

The old eunuch stared at me for a brief moment, as if he could see right through me, then spoke to Hong Jin beside him.

"It's been a long time, Hong Cheophyeong. Or should I call you Deputy Military Commissioner now?"

Hong Jin answered calmly.

"Call me whatever you like. But you've gotten even older since I last saw you."

Despite the considerable age difference between them, Hong Jin spoke to him without a hint of deference.

That meant Hong Jin's position back then must have been quite high. The old eunuch's wrinkles deepened further.

"You'd be wise to watch your words. The landscape isn't the only thing that's changed in the last ten years."

"Things can only change so much. And your brain must have gone stiff with age. It's been eleven years and nine days, to be precise."

"You remember that exactly?"

"There are some things you can't forget, even if you try."

"And yet you seem to have forgotten rather a lot."

The old eunuch continued in a chilly voice.

"How dare you bring an outsider into the imperial palace without permission—one of those ruffians from the martial world, no less. Just because you left the imperial court, have you forgotten its rules as well?"

"Times really have changed. Someone like you dares to question something His Highness Prince Shangshan permitted? And…"

Hong Jin's voice rang clear.

"If everything had gone according to the rules, things wouldn't have come to this."

"…!"

"…!"

Hong Jin's words had a hard edge beneath them, and the air around us froze.

Just as he said, if everything had followed the rules, the current Son of Heaven wouldn't be sitting on the throne, and Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao's situation would be very different.

Hong Jin had alluded to that fact, and the reaction of the Embroidered Uniform Guards and the East Depot eunuchs—the Son of Heaven's own hands and feet—had been inevitable from the start.

Shing.

The cold scrape of a blade reached my ears.

I moved without the slightest hesitation.

Whoosh.

One step.

Space disappeared. The wind fell silent.

In time that seemed to pass slowly, I reached out and pressed down on the hand of someone gripping a sword hilt tightly.

To send the blade, not even halfway drawn, back where it belonged.

Click.

At the soft sound, time—which had slowed for a moment—returned to normal. The wide eyes of an Embroidered Uniform Guard I didn't know seemed to whisper:

How?

But I didn't bother answering, nor did I knock down the man who'd already gone rigid as a statue.

Then again, even if I had answered, he might not have heard me.

The wind, catching up with me after I'd moved like a flash of light, whipped in every direction.

Fwoosh!

Clothes billowed in the burst of air.

Dust that had lain in layers between the bluestones, fitted neatly into the ground like a work of art, rose and scattered on the wind.

Like sleet.

In that breathless silence, without a single cough, I spoke calmly.

"Who the hell told you to draw your weapon? With a child—no, with His Highness Prince Shangshan watching, no less."

"…!"

"…!"

"Let's not make this any bigger than it has to be. That's best for everyone, isn't it?"

I meant every word.

Taking care of the men in front of me wouldn't be difficult, but doing that at the entrance to the imperial palace could send things spiraling into the worst possible situation.

And my sincere words reached someone I hadn't expected.

"Your manner is disrespectful, but you're not wrong."

"…!"

When did he get there?

I turned around, feeling as if someone had dumped a bucket of cold water over my head.

About thirty *jang*[3326] away, halfway down the endless staircase leading up to the imperial palace, stood a middle-aged man.

I didn't sense him at all.

I'd been constantly honing my Qi Sense so I wouldn't have to rely on the System as much as possible.

There was no denying the distance between us was considerable. But the fact that I hadn't sensed him proved the middle-aged man's martial prowess was no less than mine.

No. It might even be greater.

My thoughts turned cold as I watched him.

Instead of using lightness skill, he came slowly down the stairs with the leisurely gait of a man out for a stroll. He smiled at me and spoke.

"You're reckless, like the other ruffians of the martial world, but not as ignorant. Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

It wasn't especially surprising that the middle-aged man already knew who I was.

I'd expected as much the moment I stepped in front of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

And just as he knew who I was, I had a vague idea of who he was, too.

Even if he hadn't been wearing gleaming golden armor, the shout that rang out the next moment would've told me.

"Loyalty!"

"We pay our respects to the Commander!"

Led by Jeong Hogun, the Embroidered Uniform Guards under his command struck their chests and shouted their military salute as one. It was quite a sight.

So was the middle-aged man approaching through that sea of flashing gold.

[3326] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty *jang* is about 91 m (300 ft).

Step. Step.

His soft footsteps broke the silence that followed the shouts.

He was neither large nor small, but somehow seemed like a giant. He stopped only when he reached the young prince.

“I, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, pay my respects to His Highness Prince Shangshan. I serve only the Emperor with my utmost loyalty, so I ask you to forgive me, with a heart as vast as the sea, for not kneeling.”

His words were respectful, but his voice was light. He didn’t even show the proper deference due to a direct member of the imperial family—a prince.

And then there was that faint smile on his lips.

Still, the post of Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard carried that kind of power. He was the Son of Heaven’s most trusted military officer and the head of a force even the highest-ranking officials feared.

“Furthermore, I humbly ask that Your Highness hold me responsible for the crimes of my subordinates, who dared to show disrespect in your presence.”

That wasn’t an apology or a request. It was a notification.

He was telling us to end the matter here and now.

Even I, who was only watching for the moment, couldn’t help frowning. But Hong Jin, Prince Shangshan’s loyal servant, reacted differently from before.

Crack.

He clenched his fist so tightly that his skin turned white.

The rings on his ten fingers scraped against one another with an unpleasant sound.

Hong Jin stared at the middle-aged man—or rather, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard—with a deeply restrained gaze, then leaned toward Prince Shangshan and whispered,

“Your Highness.”

It was a quiet call, but the meaning in his suppressed voice was clear.

Hong Jin was worried about confronting Baek Yeon right now.

Whether that was because Baek Yeon held the immense power of the Embroidered Uniform Guard’s command, or for some other reason, I couldn’t say.

And looking at it coldly, I had no place in this decision.

Intervening when an Embroidered Uniform Guard drew his sword had been proper for me as the prince’s guard in name. But from here on, it was best to follow Hong Jin’s lead.

This was the imperial court, not Murim.

But the next words out of Prince Shangshan’s mouth were something no one there could have anticipated.

“If you were in my place, what would you do?”

Countless eyes turned toward me from every direction.

As I stood there, briefly at a loss for words, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao spoke again.

To me, and no one else.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. I asked what you would do in my place.”

His eyes shone brightly.

The little boy who’d been delighted to get a new autograph was nowhere to be seen. I realized that the child in my memory had grown into a young man.

I knew what answer he wanted now, too.

“Uh, may I speak honestly?”

“That is precisely what I want. This is an order from your king.”

At the prince’s bold command, I laughed aloud.

Then I looked at everyone and spoke.

“As you said, if I were in your place…”

Let’s not forget.

This was the imperial palace. I had to keep things under control.

“I’d have already beaten the shit out of every last one of them.”

“…!”

“…!”

Okay. So much for keeping it under control.

Chapter 863

Hundreds of members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard and eunuchs from the East Depot gathered in one place would have been quite a sight on its own.

But not as much as the expressions on their faces right now.

Shock. Astonishment. Confusion. Anger.

Those emotions swept across the countless faces surrounding us. Every last one of them stared wide-eyed, gaped in disbelief, wondered if they'd heard right, and then, once reality sank in, used every muscle in their faces to express their fury.

Except for two people.

"…Young Master Jin?"

Hong Jin looked at me with dazed eyes.

"Ha. Fuck. I'm screwed again…"

Hyuk Mujin dragged a hand down his face with a deep sigh.

Hmm.

Hong Jin was one thing, but Hyuk Mujin had suffered because of me more than once or twice. I did feel a little bad for him.

Still…

So what?

He could be squad leader, then.

Besides, this was a royal decree from His Highness Prince Shangshan himself. As a citizen of Korea—no, of the Great Nation—I had no choice but to follow it wholeheartedly.

Of course, I'd never even seen an identity tag bearing my name, and I had no intention of getting one. But anyway, that was the idea.

In short, this was a legally sanctioned rampage.

"I answered honestly, just as you ordered. I'm not sure whether my answer pleased you, Your Highness."

At my casual remark, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, who'd been staring at me with round eyes, flashed a mischievous grin.

"No. That was exactly the honest answer I wanted. Though I was a little surprised."

A little? He'd looked pretty damn surprised.

Even that young prince, who'd shown such unexpected boldness, seemed taken aback by just how far I'd gone.

But I didn't particularly regret it.

Whether we were in Murim or the imperial palace, this was a world where showing weakness meant getting devoured.

A rat cornered in an alley and cowering wouldn't survive long. A cat would bat it around like a toy until it finally stopped breathing.

If we have to stand up to them anyway, showing our teeth might buy us more time.

I hadn't charged in without thinking, either.

The Son of Heaven had brought Prince Shangshan all the way to the Imperial Capital. That meant he intended to get rid of him only after establishing some kind of pretext.

And that meant the hunting dogs snarling at us from every direction would stay docile until their master gave the order.

Even the pack leader with the sharpest teeth.

"Well. I hardly know what to say."

Was Baek Yeon so composed because he commanded so many members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard? Or because he was a master who'd already reached the realm of the superhuman?

Whatever the reason, his reaction was different. He didn't show the near-killing-intent fury of the others, or toy with his weapon as though killing me were his lifelong wish.

He merely stroked his beard and said, "A word of advice: watch your tongue next time. This is the imperial court of the Great Nation, not Murim."

I scratched my chin.

"I did what His Highness told me to, and now I'm getting scolded for it. How's a powerless commoner like me supposed to live with that?"

I shot a sidelong glance at the prince. He caught the signal and spoke up.

"Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard. This man merely followed my orders. You will say no more about it."

Baek Yeon didn't answer. As he looked down at the prince with an inscrutable gaze, Zhu Bao's voice grew firmer.

"I am asking you. Why do you not answer?"

Ah.

I couldn't let that go.

"That's right! How dare you ignore His Highness? You insolent bastard!"

Good projection. Good timing.

Fwoooosh.

And what an atmosphere.

My stern rebuke landed with a satisfying three-quarter beat. Energy seethed all around us.

Hong Jin let out a quiet groan. Hyuk Mujin grabbed my sleeve and whispered frantically, "Captain. Captain. Please, stop."

“His Highness Prince Shangshan, the younger brother of His Majesty the Emperor, is asking you a question! If you don’t answer, that’s an insult to the imperial family! You’re a traitor!”

“Have you actually lost your mind? Have you been dragging me around all this time just to get me killed in a place like this?”

“Let go of me, you pathetic fool who can’t even use Sword Energy! Are you on their side, too?”

“No, fuck. Please…”

Just as Hyuk Mujin was starting to sound half in tears, Baek Yeon, who’d been staring silently at Prince Shangshan the whole time, raised one hand.

Swish.

The oppressive air scattered in an instant.

The members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, furious at the insult to their superior, withdrew their auras as one. Baek Yeon opened his firmly shut lips.

“Please forgive me, Your Highness. I am slow-witted, and hesitated because I did not know how to answer.”

Not a single person here would be fool enough to take that at face value. Not even a young prince who knew nothing of the world.

“I forgive you. But having hesitated, you had better give the right answer.”

Watching Zhu Bao respond with such dignity, I realized something anew.

Regardless of his age, he was a member of the imperial family, born to noble blood. Someone destined to become a dragon if only he could obtain the dragon pearl.

Perhaps even Hong Jin, who’d stood by Prince Shangshan for so many years, had underestimated him.

Perhaps so had the all-powerful man who remembered only the child who’d barely survived countless purges and been forced to leave for Shanxi Province with the one eunuch still at his side.

“I, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, will engrave Your Highness’s command deep in my heart.”

Clank.

At the scrape of golden armor, I saw Prince Shangshan’s shoulders twitch.

He had a boldness and dignity beyond his years, but he was still a child. Facing one of the most powerful men in the Imperial Capital must have taken more courage than I’d imagined.

In that case…

A little help wouldn’t hurt.

Swish.

I murmured inwardly and, with all due insolence, brushed a hand against Prince Shangshan's back.

The young prince looked up at me, eyes wide at the sudden warmth flowing into him. Then he gave a faint smile and continued.

"These people are citizens of Shanxi Province, which I govern, and guests whom I personally invited. There must be no neglect or mishap of any kind. Is that understood?"

Baek Yeon glanced at me when he heard the prince's newly clear voice, then replied with an odd expression.

"This is the imperial palace, where His Majesty the Emperor resides. Who would dare harm Your Highness's guests?"

I muttered as if to myself, "Who knows? Someone's already drawn a sword in front of His Highness. What wouldn't they do?"

"…!"

"Good grief. The world's a frightening place these days, isn't it, Your Highness?"

At my show of distress, Prince Shangshan looked at Baek Yeon once more.

"I believe he is right. What do you think?"

A top tip for dealing with the imperial palace:

Get on good terms with a prince, and even the Emperor's right-hand man can't easily touch you—for now.

Just as I'd expected, Baek Yeon fell silent for a moment before giving the answer that had practically been decided already.

"I, too, agree with Your Highness."

"Then I have nothing more to say."

"…You honor me beyond measure."

It had been a tense exchange, with no clear victor or loser. But if I had to call it, we'd definitely come out ahead.

We'd secured a promise of safety in the Commander's name and confirmed that Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao's authority wasn't so easy to disregard.

The problem was…

Who knows how long that safety will last.

Was this what it felt like to lie on an operating table?

My companions and I were patients. Instead of kind nurses, the place was crawling with members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard and eunuchs armed with blades and spears. And the surgeon would be none other than the Son of Heaven himself.

This was the imperial palace. One word from the Emperor, who still hadn't shown his face, could change our fates.

To have your fate decided by someone you've never even seen…

This felt a lot shittier than I'd expected.

Of course, even if the Son of Heaven held the power of life and death, I had no intention of taking it lying down.

The one saving grace was that we hadn't been given a firm diagnosis yet.

Maybe it would end with a few stitches. Or maybe terrifying nurses wielding blades and spears instead of anesthetic and surgical instruments would put us to sleep for good. What happened next would depend on what we did.

No. I hoped it would.

If the surgeon had already declared us terminal, we'd have to fight for our lives with everything we had.

And Baek Yeon—the head nurse who served closest to the surgeon—had come bearing new information about that.

"By His Majesty the Emperor's command, Your Highness's audience has been postponed until tomorrow."

"Postponed? Is that what my elder brother said?"

"Yes, Your Highness."

Zhu Bao wasn't the only one whose eyes widened at the unexpected news. Hong Jin's did, too.

"But before we arrived, I was told…"

"How dare a mere eunuch interrupt, Hong Cheophyeong. No—Deputy Military Commissioner now, is it?"

They appeared to have met before. Baek Yeon cut Hong Jin off firmly and continued.

"You will attend to His Highness until you receive word."

"…Can't you at least tell us why?"

"I said it was His Majesty's command. Do you need another reason?"

Hong Jin had been about to say something, but closed his mouth.

It was the Emperor's command. There was no questioning or arguing with that. I turned the sudden postponement over in my mind.

Why? Is there a reason?

An audience that had already been arranged had been postponed. The whims of the powerful were nothing new, but given the situation, I couldn't help thinking hard about it.

Of course, with everything shrouded in fog, I couldn't get very far.

"Thousand Captain Jeong."

"Your orders?"

"Escort His Highness Prince Shangshan inside. And…"

The moment Baek Yeon's gray eyes, marked by many years despite his appearance, turned toward me—

Rumble.

I felt his aura tighten around my whole body.

That immense force had been aimed at me alone.

As soon as I realized it, I roused the internal energy sleeping deep in my lower dantian.

Whoosh.

Two invisible forces met across the empty air. They collided and mingled countless times in the blink of an eye, then finally dispersed like mist.

A voice reached me that no one else could hear.

—Not bad, young man.

Half my strength.

No—not even half of that had gone into that contest of auras.

I'd learned nothing from the exchange. Instead of answering, I licked my lips. Baek Yeon gazed at me for a moment, then finished what he'd been saying.

"The others will come as well."

"Loyalty!"

Jeong Hogun gave a vigorous military salute, then nodded to his subordinates. A wave of gold surrounded us once more, and we began to move.

Or rather, we were about to.

"Ah, I nearly forgot something."

Baek Yeon's quiet voice stopped everyone in their tracks. He walked up to one of the members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard and spoke.

"You dared to draw your sword in front of His Highness."

Shhk.

Instead of an answer came a cold slicing sound, and a head shot into the air.

Baek Yeon had cut down his subordinate with a hand blade that flashed through the air. Then he turned to Prince Shangshan and smiled.

"A subordinate's crime is my own fault. Please forgive me, Your Highness."

Chapter 864

“My subordinate’s crime is my own failing. Please forgive me, Your Highness.”

Baek Yeon smiled warmly as he looked at the young prince before him.

Prince Shangshan’s eyes shone with unusual clarity. Reflected in them was Baek Yeon, spattered with his subordinate’s blood.

He looked like a beast facing its prey.

The response came at once.

“Baek Yeon, how dare you—!”

Hong Jin sprang in front of his young lord, his voice boiling with fury. But Baek Yeon paid him no mind.

No—more precisely, he couldn’t afford to.

Someone far more dangerous than any eunuch was staring straight at him.

“This guy. I thought we were going to settle this nicely, but you’ve really crossed the line.”

At the young man’s offhand remark, Baek Yeon’s smile deepened.

“Is there a problem, Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“There is. A big one. Are you really allowed to do this?”

Jin Taekyung scratched his chin and pointed at the severed head on the ground.

Blood poured without pause from the neck, cut so cleanly it sent a shiver down his spine.

“You commit murder in front of His Highness? Is a Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard allowed to run wild like this?”

“Of course.”

“What?”

“I said I’m allowed. No matter how much power a high official wields—even if he’s a member of the imperial family—I and the Embroidered Uniform Guard serve only one person and obey his will.”

Baek Yeon raised one hand toward the dark sky, then spread both arms toward the vast buildings stretching endlessly behind him.

“The Son of Heaven. Aside from His Majesty the Emperor, who rules this world on Heaven’s behalf, who would dare punish the Embroidered Uniform Guard on a private whim?”

“…!”

“The only reason I—or rather, the Embroidered Uniform Guard—exist is to serve His Majesty. If anyone tries to undermine his authority or defy him…”

His mouth was still smiling, but his eyes weren’t.

Baek Yeon swept a cold gaze over those around him: the East Depot eunuchs, their faces stiff; Hong Jin and Hyuk Mujin, tense; and finally Jin Taekyung, standing between him and Prince Shangshan. Only then did he continue.

“Whoever they are, they won’t escape death.”

Thud.

Baek Yeon kicked the head. It rolled to a stop at someone’s feet. Jin Taekyung stared down at his leather shoe as blood soaked into it, then spoke.

“So, are you going to claim we’ve committed treason now?”

“Prince Shangshan, committing treason? Ha! That’s a frightening thing to say, my friend.”

Baek Yeon laughed aloud and waved a hand.

“No, no. I merely punished him myself.”

“Punished him?”

“He dared draw his sword in front of His Highness Prince Shangshan. That’s a capital crime. As someone said earlier, shouldn’t he be thoroughly fucked up for it?”

“I appreciate you taking my opinion into account, but it looks like there’s one more person who needs to be fucked up.”

Jin Taekyung laughed along with him.

“The man who drew his sword in front of royalty is dead. What happens to the man who spilled blood?”

“I summarily executed someone who might have become a traitor. I expect I’ll receive due praise and a reward.”

“Who says?”

“You may not know this, but incidents within the Embroidered Uniform Guard are generally resolved quickly. There are only two people who get to decide.”

Jin Taekyung let out a dry laugh.

He could already guess who they were.

One was the Son of Heaven, the very reason the Embroidered Uniform Guard existed. The other…

“The Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard?”

“Correct. You’re sharper than I expected, Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“Damn it.”

“There’s another way, so don’t be disheartened just yet. If you want me punished, you can submit a formal petition to His Majesty the Emperor. Every citizen of the Great Nation has that right. Ah, of course…”

Baek Yeon continued as if something had just occurred to him.

“That might be difficult for a martial-world ruffian without even an identity tablet.[3327]”

“…Hah.”

“There is one more way. Want to hear it?”

Jin Taekyung thought for a moment, then shook his head.

“That would be difficult.”

“Why?”

“I want to kill you, but I don’t want to die.”

“The first is absurd nonsense, but the second is a fairly sensible reason. And that answer just saved your life.”

Clank. Clank.

An unpleasant scrape sounded with every step Baek Yeon took.

Clad in golden armor that gleamed even in the dark, he stopped in front of Jin Taekyung. He looked up at the young man, who stood a head taller than he did, then turned his gaze to the young prince visible past Taekyung’s side.

“Your Highness Prince Shangshan. Do you also believe my conduct was disrespectful?”

“…”

“Your Highness. I am asking you.”

The prince’s breath trembled. But Baek Yeon’s armor wasn’t the only thing that still shone in the darkness.

“You are… truly arrogant and discourteous.”

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao trembled, but kept his eyes fixed on Baek Yeon as he continued.

“Even so, I will not blame you. Nor will I ask my elder brother, His Majesty, to punish you.”

Baek Yeon bent at the waist in an exaggerated bow.

“I am most grateful to hear that, but may I ask why?”

“You are my elder brother’s subject, not mine.”

“…!”

“Both you and I are ultimately His Majesty’s subjects. But if you were my subject, you would not escape death here today. A sovereign must not forgive a disloyal subject.”

At those words, an unreadable emotion passed over Baek Yeon’s face.

It vanished almost at once. Without a word, he turned and gestured to his subordinates with his chin.

“His Highness appears weary from the long journey. Take him inside at once.”

[3327] A *hopae* was a personal identification tablet bearing its holder’s registered identity in premodern Korea.

“Loyalty!”

“Oh, and Thousand Captain Jeong, stay behind a moment.”

The Embroidered Uniform Guard soldiers, who’d paused where they stood, closed in around the party once more.

It was impossible to tell whether they were escorting the party or surrounding them. As they moved, Baek Yeon sent a quiet Sound Transmission.

—You’ll regret coming here.

Jin Taekyung’s reply came flying back amid the golden tide flowing toward the Inner City, as though he’d been waiting for it.

—My whole life’s a regret already. Mind your own business and go suck a dick.

Who else would dare say that to the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard?

Baek Yeon let out a dry laugh at the young ruffian’s reply, which defied his expectations yet again. Leaving the East Depot eunuchs behind, he walked away.

Jeong Hogun, who had stayed at Baek Yeon’s order, followed him as a matter of course.

“Is there something you wish to command me?”

“There is. But before hearing an order, an Embroidered Uniform Guard should think for himself.”

“I will watch Prince Shangshan and his party without the slightest lapse.”

“That’s close to the answer I wanted, but not quite.”

“Then…”

“Make it look as though you’re watching them without a lapse, but leave gaps all the same. Make sure someone can slip through and approach them.”

“…!”

Clank. Clank.

Baek Yeon climbed the stairs that stretched upward without end. Hundreds, even thousands of them. They symbolized the Son of Heaven’s authority.

No matter how high an official’s rank, every time they went to court, they had to climb those stairs drenched in sweat.

Leaving behind their power and their gold and silver treasures.

Reminded of the Son of Heaven’s majesty, which reached all the way to Heaven.

“Watch whom they meet and who comes to see them. Find out everything.”

To catch fish in a net, you first had to spread it wide.

Only then did you draw it tight and haul it in.

Of course, you also had to consider the possibility that something bulky or sharp-toothed might tear through it.

“How is ‘that matter’ I entrusted to you some time ago?”

No answer came. Jeong Hogun lowered his head in silence, and Baek Yeon clicked his tongue softly.

“Cunning bastards.”

“I have nothing to say. I did my best, but…”

“It doesn’t matter. Not yet. But there must not be a second mistake.”

“Of course. Give me the order, and I will carry it out without fail.”

“Without fail? Whatever the order?”

“Yes.”

Baek Yeon suddenly stopped and turned to look at Jeong Hogun. A silent whisper slipped through his slightly parted lips.

—If I ordered you to assassinate His Highness Prince Shangshan, would you do it?

“…!”

Jeong Hogun’s eyes widened, his pupils wavering. Baek Yeon looked down at his subordinate without a word, then chuckled.

“No need to be so shocked. It was only a joke.”

“A joke…?”

“Yes. But I really am curious about your answer.”

A bead of cold sweat ran down Jeong Hogun’s forehead. He hadn’t even noticed it forming.

His silence did not last long.

“I will follow your orders with my life. If they are the Emperor’s command.”

The smile slowly faded from Baek Yeon’s lips. He studied his subordinate with an odd expression, then smiled faintly again.

“You’re right. That is an answer worthy of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.”

“…I apologize.”

“What are you apologizing for? The Embroidered Uniform Guard lives and dies by the Emperor’s command. Of course we act only according to His Majesty’s will.”

Baek Yeon turned his head.

Far in the distance, he could see a procession of torches and golden armor stretching out one after another.

And though he could not see him now, the prince with dragon’s blood was somewhere within that ironclad escort.

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

The young prince might not remember, but the old officer remembered clearly.

The Son of Heaven’s only younger brother. The sole direct member of the imperial family to survive the most brutal power struggle in history.

The child he had last seen more than a decade ago had grown considerably. In body and in mind.

"…Which makes him all the more dangerous."

Jeong Hogun lifted his head at Baek Yeon's whispered words.

Baek Yeon waved a hand as if nothing had happened, then spoke again. Not a trace of a smile remained on his stern face.

"Remember one thing."

"Give me your command."

"Once they've set foot in this imperial palace, no one is to be allowed to leave."

Jeong Hogun understood at once.

Baek Yeon wasn't speaking only of Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard had to watch more than the prince with dragon's blood. There was also the martial-world ruffian who dared bear the title of Divine Dragon.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

The dragon was a mythical spiritual creature that symbolized the Son of Heaven alone.

Yet the young prince had brought an uninvited Divine Dragon into the imperial palace where the Son of Heaven resided.

He had made that ruffian, who disregarded the laws of the Great Nation, his guard. He had defended him and taken him under his protection.

No one could be certain what that choice would bring.

Not Jeong Hogun. Not even Baek Yeon, who had anticipated the situation and let it happen.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung they knew had always been like that.

He always overturned everyone's expectations, bringing storms and flames that swept in from every direction.

Fwoosh.

In the darkness, a fierce wind blew from somewhere, setting the torches flickering.

Chapter 865

A person’s body and mind are like a bowstring.

Drawn taut, then released all at once.

Once the tension lets up, exhaustion catches up with you.

That was true even for me, after weathering countless crises. For a child barely twelve or thirteen, it went without saying.

Click.

Careful not to wake his young lord, Hong Jin closed the door with the utmost care and whispered to me,

“He must have been exhausted. He fell asleep in no time.”

Soft, even breathing came through the crack in the closed door.

Once I was sure Prince Shangshan was fast asleep, I glanced out the window.

Down below, amid the swaying torchlight, members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard stood like iron towers in their golden armor.

You bastards. It’s dark enough already. Why don’t you clock out on time for once?

Of course, that wasn’t going to happen.

From what I’d seen, those guys would risk not just overtime but their lives to carry out an order.

Murim martial artists were all crazy in their own way, but the Embroidered Uniform Guard were hunting dogs, blindly loyal to the Son of Heaven.

“Watching us like that won’t change anything. They won’t leave their posts for even a moment.”

Hong Jin surveyed the torches and guards surrounding the pavilion as if they were laying siege to it, then added, “That’s how the Changwei operate.”

“Changwei?”

“Oh, it’s a collective name for the East Depot and the Embroidered Uniform Guard. As I told you, Young Master Jin, I was once part of one of them.”

I knew Hong Jin had belonged to the East Depot, but there was still plenty I wanted to ask him.

As if he’d read my mind, Hong Jin spoke first.

“Now that it’s finally just the two of us, shall we talk for a bit?”

I’d be grateful if he did.

I nodded, and Hong Jin and I walked downstairs together.

We’d already sent away the Embroidered Uniform Guard, along with the palace attendants who were more or less there to keep an eye on us for them.

Even though I could see everything happening inside the pavilion as clearly as if it were in the palm of my hand, Hong Jin was still deeply uneasy about leaving Prince Shangshan alone.

“Young Master Jin, do you think it’s all right?”

“There’s no need to worry. I’m nearby, and more importantly, I left that rascal Mujin with His Highness as a precaution.”

“Right. That makes me even more worried.”

“…”

Thank goodness Hyuk Mujin hadn’t heard that. I stepped into an empty room.

As befitted a pavilion belonging to the imperial palace, it was spacious, with a faint fragrance drifting among the antique furnishings.

Best of all, there’s no chance anyone’s bugging us.

Back in the modern world, I’d worried about being overheard whenever I had an important conversation. Murim was old-fashioned enough that I could talk without a care.

“Finally, I can breathe a little. Don’t you think?”

Hong Jin seemed to feel much the same way. He brought a lit candelabra over to the window to brighten the dark room, then sat down and spoke, looking tired.

“I’m sure you have a lot you want to ask me, Young Master Jin, but could I speak first?”

“Go ahead.”

“Don’t provoke him more than necessary. Whatever you do.”

He hadn’t said who he meant, but I knew at once.

“Baek Yeon?”

“That’s right. Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard. Keep as much distance between you and him as you can.”

I didn’t ask why. There was no need.

He commanded the Embroidered Uniform Guard, was an exceptionally skilled Supreme Peak master, and was the military officer the Son of Heaven trusted most.

Any one of those would have been reason enough for caution. All three together left nothing to discuss.

But…

“I think we’ve already gotten a little too close for that.”

Hong Jin sighed.

“I know. I saw everything with my own two eyes. I’m just asking you to be careful from now on.”

His worry showed in his expression, his voice, even the way he spoke.

The Hong Jin I knew had plenty of nerve. The East Depot, made up of eunuchs, was a ruthless organization that served as the Emperor's human-cleanup crew alongside the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

He seemed to have held a fairly high position there, so he must have been through all sorts of hell. He'd even sneered while dealing with Jeong Hogun and the other guards, and with the East Depot eunuchs.

Until Baek Yeon appeared.

"Is there another reason I don't know about?"

Hong Jin's answer made his concern clear.

"Thirty thousand. That's how many people Baek Yeon captured and killed in the last coup."

"…!"

"How did the fourth prince, already sidelined in the struggle for succession, manage to seize the throne of the Great Nation? Because he was exceptionally capable? No. That wasn't enough. He needed a cause, and he needed people. No one becomes the Son of Heaven by their own strength alone."

Hong Jin rushed through the words, then took a long-stemmed tobacco pipe from inside his clothes and put it to his mouth.

Before long, pungent smoke rose around him. His face looked especially dark through the haze as he continued.

"Baek Yeon was already head of the Embroidered Uniform Guard long before I entered the imperial palace. He had the late Emperor's full trust from a young age, and for a time, he even taught the Crown Prince martial arts."

"The Crown Prince—you mean the one…?"

"That's right. So when Baek Yeon helped the fourth prince stage a coup, everyone was stunned. No one thought *he*, of all people, would betray the late Emperor and the Crown Prince."

Hoooo.

Smoke curled up from Hong Jin's lips. Through the pale haze, it was almost as if the past he remembered were passing before him.

"It began in an instant and was over just as quickly. They moved so secretly that even the East Depot couldn't do a thing. No—perhaps it's more accurate to say we were caught off guard because we never saw it coming."

The coup began in the dead of night and was over around dawn.

The pounding of hooves echoed across the Imperial Capital until daybreak, and the screams never stopped.

"The coup was… perfect enough to make your skin crawl. Every civil and military official had gathered to celebrate His Majesty the Emperor's birthday, along with members of the imperial family from every corner of the land. Security was tighter than ever against any possible threat. Except for one thing."

This wasn't some village headman's birthday. It was the birthday of the Emperor, ruler of an entire continent.

I could almost see it all before me: the packed crowds that day, and the dazzling golden armor of the guards who had sealed off the imperial palace.

"…The Embroidered Uniform Guard. They were in charge of the palace defenses."

Hong Jin gave a bitter smile and nodded.

"Yes. That's right."

Everything had been prepared down to the last detail.

Baek Yeon and the guards who followed him took control of the imperial palace in an instant. As everyone looked on in shock, the fourth prince alone rose to his feet and stepped onto the stage prepared for him, his expression calm.

It was the moment the history of the Great Nation changed.

"And then… the purge began."

The unexpected spectacle was over, but no one left their seats. No—no one *could* leave.

The people who had arrived as nothing more than spectators were forced to become actors in the next performance.

"Those who submitted at once survived. Those who resisted were dragged off to the prisons controlled by the Embroidered Uniform Guard. The imperial family had it a little better, at least. At first, they were only confined."

The Emperor—no, the late Emperor—was already old. He was locked inside his residence. The Crown Prince and his wife, and the rest of the imperial family, were no exception.

They endured day after day under relentless watch, trembling at the screams that rang out day and night beyond the high walls surrounding them.

Waiting for their turn to come.

"Countless people died in the process. More families than anyone could count were wiped out. And…"

Hong Jin let his voice trail off before adding, "The man who led the purge was the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard. No—the Blood Envoy, Baek Yeon."

"The Blood Envoy…"

"Every time I hear it, I think how well that sobriquet suits him. Don't you?"

Hong Jin's lips curled into a smile, but it was feeble and vanished almost immediately.

"Young Master Jin. Back then, I couldn't do anything. I failed to detect the treason, so I was incompetent as a subject. And all I could do was watch it happen, so I was powerless. But one thing hasn't changed, then or now."

Tap.

Hong Jin knocked the ash from his pipe. He looked up as if he could see through the ceiling to where the young prince lay sleeping, then continued.

"I must protect His Highness Prince Shangshan. That was the late Emperor's final wish. It's also the last act of loyalty I can offer as a servant who was both incompetent and powerless."

His voice fell silent.

In the heavy silence, I turned over what he'd told me, then spoke abruptly.

"I'm not sure that's really loyalty."

"Hmm?"

"A subject wanting to protect his lord and a parent worrying about a child are two different things. And from what I've seen of you, Deputy Military Commissioner, it's more like the latter."

"What are you trying to say?"

"It's simple. His Highness Prince Shangshan isn't just a child who needs someone to protect him."

Hong Jin sighed.

"Young Master Jin, I'm sorry, but he's still young. He's only thirteen."

"That's right. Only thirteen—and already able to make the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, a man whose influence could knock birds from the sky, bow his head. Already able to keep his composure while people die right in front of him."

"…!"

Sometimes. Maybe even fairly often.

People caught up in their personal feelings make the wrong call.

Even if that person is a eunuch from the East Depot who's been through hell and back.

I held Hong Jin's frozen gaze and continued.

"His Highness Prince Shangshan isn't a child who needs someone else to protect him. He's been a king for a long time already. He just hasn't fully come into his own yet."

"Young Master Jin, you…"

"If all he wanted was to survive, he could throw himself at the Emperor's feet tomorrow and beg for his life. He could plead that he had no idea what crime he'd committed and ask to be spared just this once. Assuming, of course, that his desperate plea stirs the Emperor's tender heart."

"…!"

"But you have something else in mind, don't you, Deputy Military Commissioner?"

Hong Jin stared at me, his face set, then asked in a dry voice, "What makes you think that?"

“At a time when you should be bending over backward to please the Emperor, you dared to bring martial-world ruffians into the imperial palace. You dared to speak provocatively in front of the East Depot and the Embroidered Uniform Guard. And…”

I suddenly turned around and continued slowly.

“Late tonight, you brought an uninvited guest all the way here without the Embroidered Uniform Guard noticing.”

At that moment—

Fwoosh. Whoosh.

The three candles Hong Jin had lit when he entered the room went out at once.

I looked from Hong Jin to the black figure that had appeared out of thin air, then back again.

“So, when are you going to introduce us?”

Chapter 866

An uninvited guest turning up at night was never welcome.

Especially when he was a Supreme Peak master with extraordinary concealment techniques.

“Young Master Jin, I know it’s late, but let me introduce you. This is…”

“No need. I barged in without permission, so the least I can do is introduce myself.”

Slide.

The stranger interrupted Hong Jin and pulled down his mask, revealing a smooth, clean-shaven face.

His build was so androgynous it was hard to guess his gender, and he looked a good ten years younger than Hong Jin.

Then there was his martial prowess. He had reached Supreme Peak.

Put all those clues together, and it wasn’t hard to guess who the uninvited guest was.

“The East Depot?”

The stranger nodded.

“You’ve got a sharp eye.”

As if turning up uninvited weren’t enough, he was talking down to me, too.

I didn’t like it, but in a way, that made things easier.

I could do the same.

“Well, if I couldn’t figure out that much, I might as well go die.”

“And you don’t hold back when you speak.”

“Think my mouth’s the only thing I don’t hold back?”

“Good. Very good.”

The stranger smiled soundlessly and clasped his hands in a formal salute.

“Let me introduce myself properly. I’m Ma Sanbao, Brush-Holding Eunuch of the East Depot.”

Brush-Holding Eunuch of the East Depot? Ma Sanbao?

The title sounded important enough, but his name was on the level of Gaettong from next door.

Hong Jin saw the question in my eyes and spoke up.

“The Brush-Holding Eunuch is the East Depot’s second-in-command. In terms of rank, he comes right after the Chief Eunuch.”

I stared at the stranger—or rather, Ma Sanbao.

His position was more impressive than I'd imagined, but I was even more curious why a big shot like the East Depot's second-in-command had come here in secret at this late hour.

Especially after I'd seen how that old eunuch treated Hong Jin earlier.

"Hadn't you already fallen out with the East Depot? Judging by what happened earlier, things didn't look good between you."

Ma Sanbao laughed again, though I'd asked Hong Jin.

"You're certainly no ordinary young man. To bring that up so casually right in front of me…"

"I wasn't asking you."

"Doesn't matter. I'm glad it looked that way. If even someone on our side was fooled, the Embroidered Uniform Guard won't suspect a thing."

Fooled?

I stopped short and looked at Hong Jin.

"…That was an act? All of it?"

"To be precise, it was planned from the start. But I wouldn't call it an act. He's disliked me for a long time."

Ma Sanbao nodded at Hong Jin's answer.

"Mm. A long time. More than thirty years, if I remember right."

"You chose your man well, Ma Constable. Or should I call you Eunuch Ma now?"

"My, you've grown even more mischievous since I last saw you. A man like me would never have dared dream of taking your place. I've only been keeping it for you."

"Not at all."

Hong Jin's answer was firm.

"You're more than qualified for that position. You were then, and you are now."

"…Good grief. Come to think of it, I forgot to greet you."

Shaking his head, Ma Sanbao patted Hong Jin's shoulder. His face held equal parts bitterness and joy.

"Even if the timing couldn't be worse, I'm glad to see you again, even like this."

"Likewise."

Watching two men without balls have an emotional reunion, I felt hot tears begin to run down my face—

No, I didn't.

An emotional reunion, my ass.

They hadn't even told me what was going on. Why the hell would I cry?

Still, even I had to admit there was something heartwarming about the sight of them gripping each other's shoulders.

And beyond the sentiment, Ma Sanbao was the East Depot's second-in-command.

Nothing in their conversation so far had sounded like bad news.

A secret pact.

They must have arranged this beforehand. I just didn't know where it had begun or how far it went.

I didn't have to wait long for an explanation. The two finished their brief reunion and took turns speaking.

"Eunuch Ma and I are from the same cohort. We first set foot in the imperial palace on the same day."

"And got cut on the same day, too. Remember? You were right ahead of me in line."

"Was I?"

"I remember it clearly. You didn't let out a single scream. I thought you were one tough bastard."

I listened for a moment, then asked, feeling queasy. My tone was a little more polite than before.

"Um, when you say you both got cut on the same day…"

"What else would it be? That."

"That's right. That."

"…Oh."

I'd suspected as much, but was this for real?

Ball buddies.

So this was the amazing imperial palace.

Childhood buddies? Coworkers who'd started on the same day? Neither could hold a candle to these two.

They'd been cut together before entering the palace. Their bond had to be on a whole other level.

"We joined the East Depot around the same time and rose through the ranks together."

"That sounds about right. Except you were always one step ahead of me."

"At times, perhaps. But Cang Gong always trusted you most, Eunuch Ma. And when it came to martial arts talent, no one in the East Depot could match you. Certainly not me."

I didn't know how much of their conversation was true, but it suddenly struck me that Hong Jin's assessment of Ma Sanbao's martial arts was probably not exaggerated in the slightest.

The qi I'd sensed from Ma Sanbao the moment I saw him was in no way inferior to mine or Baek Yeon's.

Of course, internal energy isn't everything.

I muttered to myself and looked Ma Sanbao over from head to toe.

His height. The length of his arms and legs. Which muscles were especially developed, and what weapon he might use.

At this point, it was practically an occupational hazard bordering on a mental disorder. But sizing up someone I'd just met was an important habit.

Provided I didn't needlessly offend him.

"Young man, you've got a remarkably keen eye."

At Ma Sanbao's sudden remark, I clicked my tongue inwardly.

"I was about to say the same about you."

"What, surprised I noticed so quickly?"

"Mm. A little."

"An old habit. I may not be a Murim martial artist like you, but I have to stay alert wherever I go."

I'd examined him as discreetly as possible, in a fraction of a second—too quickly for him to have noticed.

Yet Ma Sanbao had caught me while talking with Hong Jin. His Qi Sense was better than that of most Supreme Peak masters.

So this is the East Depot.

The East Depot and the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

I'd already heard what these two organizations, collectively known as the Changwei, did.

Assassination of important figures. Surveillance, intelligence gathering, and more.

They were intelligence agents trained to the limit, skilled assassins, and soldiers.

And with the Son of Heaven's dazzling authority behind them, I'd heard they also served as a law enforcement agency.

Their influence and military strength had to be immense.

Even the low-ranking Embroidered Uniform Guard and East Depot eunuchs I've seen were no ordinary people.

"No ordinary people" didn't begin to cover it.

Even the weakest were Supreme First Rate, and more than half were Peak masters.

On the way to the imperial palace, I'd seen hundreds of Peak masters with my own eyes.

If those were only a fraction of their forces, what they had yet to reveal was terrifying.

And if the imperial palace joined hands with Dark Heaven—if, by some chance, it really came to that…

A cold shiver ran up my spine. My face, reflected in Ma Sanbao's eyes, had stiffened without me noticing.

"You're wary of me."

"Let's call it questions rather than wariness. For now."

"For now?"

"I don't need you to tell me you two are close. What I want to know is that there still seem to be a lot of facts I haven't heard."

"Yes, I suppose there is."

Ma Sanbao dropped into an empty chair and continued.

"How much do I need to tell you to answer your questions?"

"Everything. From beginning to end."

"Everything would take too long to tell tonight. But there's one thing I should tell you first."

"Let's hear it, then."

"About a month ago, I sent someone a secret letter. It said that some members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard were heading north under concealed identities. I also included my own suspicion that they were bound for Shanxi Province."

Hong Jin picked up the story quietly.

"Thanks to the information Eunuch Ma sent me, I had time to prepare, even if it wasn't much. Asking Young Master Jin for help was a decision I made after careful thought."

"…!"

This was news to me.

I'd assumed Hong Jin had chosen me because he was desperate and had no one else to turn to.

But I was wrong.

Hong Jin had thought it through carefully and asked me for help.

And through it all, someone had been helping him from behind the scenes.

No matter how capable Hong Jin was, he couldn't keep track of everything happening in the imperial capital from over ten thousand *li*[3328] away.

But the East Depot's second-in-command could.

The East Depot had spies planted throughout the land, watching for any movement. There was no question they'd know what was happening in the imperial capital—their own front yard.

That still didn't answer everything.

"I understand that you helped save His Highness Prince Shangshan. But…"

"I think I know what you're going to say. Yes, you're right. I've sworn loyalty to His Majesty."

Ma Sanbao spoke before I could continue. Then, in a low voice, he added:

"Not the traitor sitting on the throne now. The late Emperor."

[3328] A Chinese *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi); ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

"…!"

"Do you know why I've remained in the imperial palace all this time? How I've managed it?"

Tap. Tap.

Drops of blood fell through the gaps in his white-knuckled fist. The East Depot's second-in-command went on in a sharp voice unlike any I'd heard from him before.

"Because there was something I had to do. Because I had to endure whatever hardships came and wait for my moment…!"

He couldn't shout the words aloud. The cry struck the internal energy I'd spread around us and faded away.

Ma Sanbao's lips trembled as he let emotions hidden for more than a decade show on his face.

He looked at his longtime friend and spoke in a voice seething with feeling.

"Hong Jin. Hong Constable. My friend and comrade. The time has finally come. We can't put it off any longer."

"Eunuch Ma. You don't mean…"

"I do."

Rumble.

A thunderous boom rang out without warning, and the dark sky blazed with light. Rain poured and lightning flashed beyond the window behind Ma Sanbao as he ground out the words.

"Let's set right, with our own hands, the sky that traitor has thrown into chaos."

Chapter 867

Rumble.

Thunder rolled across the sky. As dazzling lightning flashed and torrential rain came pouring down, the palace attendants hurried about.

Eunuchs and palace maids scurried toward the quarters of the consorts they served, worried that rainwater might be leaking in. The Embroidered Uniform Guards stationed throughout the imperial palace stood their ground beneath their broad-brimmed hats.

Everyone who worked in the imperial palace had a role to play.

Do your job well, and you were rewarded. Fail to, and you were punished.

Yet one man strolled through the relentless downpour at his leisure. He was one of the few people in this vast palace who needn't concern himself with rewards or punishments.

No—in fact, it was closer to the opposite.

He wielded such immense authority that he could reward or punish others without the Son of Heaven's approval.

And yet no palace attendant dared try to catch his eye or get close to him.

Not even the rain pouring ceaselessly down at that very moment.

Whoosh.

Though he walked through the downpour, not a drop of water touched him.

His half-white hair, tousled as it pleased, was bone-dry. His golden armor, polished with oil-treated cloth, still gleamed brilliantly.

It was a strange, almost unreal sight, but then, he was no ordinary man.

Immense authority wasn't all he possessed.

Raw power.

Martial prowess far beyond the limits of human ability.

He had the power to make the unreal real. With an important meeting ahead of him, he simply didn't want to get wet.

Vwoom.

The air trembled with his profound internal energy. Rain struck an invisible barrier and scattered in every direction, unable to touch him.

"It's been quiet lately, but now it's really coming down…"

Muttering as he looked up at the sky flashing with lightning, the man resumed his steps. No one dared stand in his way.

No one had in the past. No one did now. And no one would in the future.

Clank. Rumble.

The mere sight of him approaching from afar was enough.

The Embroidered Uniform Guards peered out from beneath their deeply lowered hats. Without a moment's hesitation, they opened the firmly shut gates and kept their heads bowed until he had passed.

The same was true of those quietly performing their duties out of sight.

"Open the way."

At his sudden command, the vast garden, filled with all manner of rare flowers and plants, shimmered like a heat haze.

Whoosh.

Even the foreign trees and flowers that had stood tall against the fierce wind and rain lowered their heads.

Thick leaves and branches slid aside, revealing a hidden path where only those granted permission could set foot.

Beautiful flowers have thorns.

The imperial palace's gardens were no different. An unwelcome guest fooled by their beauty into stepping inside would find himself surrounded by countless mechanisms and formations and riddled with holes.

And it wasn't just the gardens.

The imperial palace itself was a den of dangers, a demon-slaying battleground—a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords in the truest sense.

Anyone without permission would die.

Even someone whose martial prowess reached the heavens could not be sure of surviving.

As the man passed through five gates and dozens of pavilions, he was reminded of that once more. At last, he reached his destination and stopped.

Qianqing Palace.

Beneath a signboard inscribed in a bold, soaring hand, two middle-aged men stood like iron towers. They lowered their heads in greeting.

"You've arrived."

"You've arrived."

Their voices and expressions were as alike as if they were one person.

Their faces, too, made it plain they had been born of the same womb on the same day.

The twins continued politely.

"Please wait a moment."

"Please wait a moment."

The man frowned. Not because they were speaking in unison again, despite how many times he had told them not to, but because of the strong smell of blood coming from them.

"Looks like you had a guest."

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

“Did you kill him? Who was behind it?”

“He took his own life just before we could capture him.”

“He took his own life just before—”

“Enough. How many times have I told you once is enough? So you failed to take the intruder alive?”

The twins blinked at him, looking unsure what to do, then mumbled under their breath.

“He had a potent poison hidden beneath one of his molars.”

“He had a potent poison hidden—no, we did everything we could, but we couldn’t stop him. We beg your forgiveness.”

The man clicked his tongue softly.

The fact that the intruder had made it this far was proof of his extraordinary martial prowess.

Failing to capture him and learn who was behind him was a painful mistake, but something mattered more than reprimanding the twins right now.

“Don’t tell me he got inside the palace.”

“Of course not.”

“Of course not.”

At least that’s a relief. The man asked another question.

“Is he inside?”

“He’s waiting.”

“He’s waiting.”

The man nodded, glanced up at the signboard, then stepped forward.

Qianqing Palace. Qianqing—“clear sky.” Those two characters seemed a poor fit for today.

Step. Step.

The palace interior was quiet.

Not a person—or even a rat—could be seen. Only the countless paintings and works of art hanging on the walls glimmered in the faint light.

But what he could see wasn’t everything.

With every step, the man felt eyes following him. Shadows ready to rush out and cut him to pieces if he posed even the slightest threat, whoever he might be.

At last, he stopped. Before him was a vast space prepared for one person alone, and there its master waited.

No—the master of all under heaven.

“I, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, have come at the summons of Your Majesty, the august Emperor.”

At that moment—

Rustle.

The colorful silk curtains draped around the room stirred.

Through the thin silk, amid wisps of faintly fragrant smoke, he glimpsed the back of someone dressed in dazzling white.

“You’ve come.”

A quiet voice echoed through the room. At first, it sounded calm, almost languid.

The Son of Heaven of the Great Nation continued slowly, as if speaking to himself.

“I had a bad dream. A dream that someone was trying to harm me.”

“…!”

“I fought for a long time, covered in blood. They came at me from somewhere, without end, and I cut them down without end. Only when I finally woke did I realize it hadn’t been a mere dream.”

Baek Yeon raised his head in silence. Pale smoke drifted from between the Son of Heaven’s lips.

“So you’ve turned to poppy again.”

“Does this look like poppy to you?”

“Forgive me, but that is exactly what it looks like to me.”

“You’re wrong. This isn’t poppy. It’s medicine—the only thing that can heal me.”

Baek Yeon’s brow twitched.

“Your Majesty, may I speak with you about something important?”

The Son of Heaven didn’t answer. Instead, he flicked his long, wide sleeve.

Swish.

With a faint rustle, the presences surrounding them withdrew like the tide. Baek Yeon straightened from his bow, his voice cold.

“Your Majesty, with the great undertaking nearly complete, why would you disgrace yourself like this?”

If anyone else had been there, they would have covered their eyes and ears.

Baek Yeon’s tone was far too sharp for a subject speaking to his ruler. It was more than insolent—it was defiant.

Yet the Son of Heaven didn’t answer this time, either. The ruler of the world gave a low laugh instead. Only after a long while did he speak.

“The great undertaking. Yes. There was a great undertaking.”

“Please don’t forget the promise we made that day.”

“Forget?”

The Son of Heaven muttered with a short, incredulous laugh.

“I haven’t forgotten. Not for a single moment since that day.”

His voice was as weak as a sick man’s.

But Baek Yeon’s eyes, fixed on the Son of Heaven, didn’t waver. They were sunk deep and steady.

“They’ve already begun to move. Before everything falls apart, remember that you must put things back where they belong.”

After a brief silence, the Son of Heaven nodded quietly.

He had come too far to turn back. Once no more than the fourth prince, he now ruled all under heaven. And he had become a man who could no longer get by without poppy.

Wasn’t it said that a horse racing across the wilderness never looked back?

Even the Son of Heaven, who stood above all people, was no exception.

He was a horse that could no longer stop of its own will. Even if it collapsed coughing up blood, it had to keep running toward its destination.

Crack.

His hand clenched instinctively, snapping the ornate long-stemmed tobacco pipe. The Son of Heaven stared at the broken pieces in his palm, then closed his fist tightly around them.

Thump.

The rough pieces dug into his palm. Pain flared like a burn, and little by little, his mind began to clear.

“Ah.”

As if worshiping the heavens, the Son of Heaven tilted his head back toward the ceiling and groaned with his eyes closed.

Baek Yeon watched impassively.

“Shall I call for the imperial physician?”

“No need. Not for an imperial physician.”

The Son of Heaven opened his eyes and continued, his voice clearer now.

“Tomorrow, I’ll meet that child in the audience hall.”

“That child would be…”

“Zhu Bao. I wonder how much my… only younger brother has grown.”

Baek Yeon nodded.

“You can look forward to it. He’s grown even more than Your Majesty expects.”

“Which means he’s become even more dangerous.”

“…”

Baek Yeon pressed his lips together, but the Son of Heaven understood.

All sorts of bugs gather around a tempting meal.

Now that Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao had appeared in the Imperial Capital, the enemies who resented him would surely draw the blades they had kept hidden beneath their sleeves.

Just like the nameless assassin who had come here before Baek Yeon today.

“Baek Yeon, this must never happen again. Remember that.”

His voice was different now, cold as ice. Baek Yeon faltered, then answered with a faint smile.

“I will engrave Your Majesty’s words into my bones. Please forgive my disloyalty until now.”

Flutter.

In response, the Son of Heaven merely waved his sleeve. Baek Yeon turned and began walking away.

After only a few steps, he stopped.

“And what of that man?”

“If you mean…”

“Zhu Bao. The Murim martial artist who came with him.”

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

Baek Yeon thought carefully about the man who had suddenly come to mind. A long while passed before he spoke.

“I don’t know.”

He had interrogated and killed tens of thousands on the battlefield, and tens of thousands more in the imperial palace.

But that was the best answer Baek Yeon could give.

Chapter 868

The night Ma Sanbao came to see me, I couldn't sleep.

It wasn't just the rain, pouring down as if the heavens had decided to empty themselves, or the lightning crashing all around us.

My last conversation with Ma Sanbao kept replaying in my head. He'd vanished as suddenly as he'd appeared.

I need your help.

When he first said it, I couldn't bring myself to answer.

This was a plot against the throne. There was no denying it.

If I agreed and things went wrong, no one could say what would happen afterward. With the imperial family involved, they wouldn't treat it as one man's wrongdoing.

I wouldn't pay the price for failure as the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. I'd pay it as Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. That weighed heavily on me.

What happens if this fails?

You already know, don't you?

…

Fail, and you're a traitor. Succeed, and you're the Son of Heaven. In the latter case, wealth and glory beyond anyone else's reach await you. In the former, you'll suffer worse than you would in hell.

I'd fought countless battles and brought down more enemies than I could count.

Some had been weak enough to handle with one finger. Others had frightened me so badly I couldn't move a finger.

But… this was different.

The Great Nation ruled the world, and the Son of Heaven ruled the Great Nation. To rebel against the Son of Heaven meant fighting the world itself.

Not just me. Everyone around me.

Think carefully. Of course, since you set foot in the imperial palace to protect His Highness Prince Shangshan, it may already be too late.

Are you threatening me?

No. I'm telling you the truth.

Ma Sanbao, the East Depot's second-in-command. I could still see the cold, piercing look in his eyes and hear the low voice in which he'd spoken.

How many people do you think died in the last coup? Tens of thousands were made to drink poison, died for unknown reasons on the road to exile, were torn limb from limb in the marketplace, or had their heads put on display. And those are only the

deaths the world knows about. How many were never brought to light? How many of those people had nothing to do with it, just like you?

…!

"They call it 'calling a deer a horse.' In the end, everything depends on the Emperor's will. Just as a perfectly ordinary deer can become a horse, you can be made a traitor. Remember that."

History had proven how fickle and suspicious those in power could be.

And the current Son of Heaven was undeniably a tyrant. A usurper who had defied the natural order and climbed to the throne through blood, a ruler who wielded absolute power.

Hearing Ma Sanbao say it, I began to realize what that meant.

Whether I became a traitor might already be out of my hands.

Of course, I won't deny that I had a hand in their deaths. No—I led the way. I had to survive, whatever it took. I had to stay here and wait for the right moment.

Some had left the imperial palace to serve their young master. Others had remained to welcome him back one day.

Hong Jin was one of the former. Ma Sanbao was one of the latter.

He became the fourth prince's—no, the new Emperor's—hunting dog.

He was one of the cruelest of them, sinking his teeth into his targets' necks without mercy. He survived that brutal purge and rose to become the East Depot's second-in-command, its Brush-Holding Eunuch.

And Ma Sanbao wasn't the only one who had survived that way.

The night we all gathered, Cang Gong said that if the East Depot had been a flower blooming in the dark until then, we had to become weeds from that day on.

Flowers were bright and beautiful whether there was light or not.

Weeds weren't. No one spared a glance for plain, nameless grass. And because of that, it survived longer.

Cang Gong, the East Depot's head and its Seal-Holding Eunuch, had urged his like-minded comrades to survive as weeds. He kept urging them until the illness brought on by his long years finally laid him low.

Five years ago, after Cang Gong took to his sickbed, I began leading everyone. That was when I started drawing up the pledge.

The pledge.

Clear proof that the traitors had signed their names in their own blood—and perhaps a record of the names of the meritorious officials who would one day enthrone a new Son of Heaven.

Ma Sanbao had mentioned the pledge before he left. Then he'd said something that was bound to keep me awake all night.

Dark Heaven. I know about the people throwing Murim into turmoil. Probably far more about them than you imagine, and in far greater detail.

…!

Even if you leave now, I won't try to stop you. But if you help us enthrone His Highness Prince Shangshan and put a new order in place… we'll have to give you a fitting reward.

Ma Sanbao left, Hong Jin returned to the young prince's side, and I stayed where I was, lost in thought.

Until the first light of dawn reached the window. Until the rain began to let up and day broke in the distance.

And right up to this moment.

"Fuck."

At my sudden curse, Hyuk Mujin jolted awake from where he'd been nodding off in a corner. He sprang to his feet and fumbled for the sword in his arms, eyes still half shut.

"Are we under attack? An attack? You bastards! Who the hell dares—"

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Go to sleep."

"Yes."

Hyuk Mujin flopped back down as if nothing had happened and was asleep again in no time.

The trip to the imperial capital must have been exhausting, but sleeping in that position for four whole *shichen*[3329] was a talent in itself.

Snore.

…

Still, snoring crossed the line.

Whack!

"Ugh! You bastards! No one lays a finger on the Captain!"

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"If you're supposed to be standing guard and you sleep that soundly, they could lay hands on every part of me except one hair."

"Gasp! Someone's already laid a hand on you, Captain? No, you don't have to tell me. It was Hong Jin, wasn't it? I knew it. The way he's always looked at you was lecherous…"

"Mujin. You little shit…!"

[3329] A traditional time division of about two hours. Four *shichen* is about eight hours.

I groaned from the depths of my soul.

Of all people, this idiot was my right-hand man—or rather, my pinky toe.

Things were serious enough as it was, and with him like this, I'd hit a proper moment of clarity. At this point, I was starting to wonder if Dark Heaven had sent him as an ascension-to-immortality hitman to make sure I left this world early.

No System. No one I can rely on right now, either.

Thinking about it, I'd been pretty lucky until now.

The System had always pointed me toward where I needed to go, even if it did so vaguely through Quests. And whenever I wavered, Jeok Cheongang had been a sturdy pillar I could trust and lean on.

Now I had neither.

Everything that happened from here on would depend on the choice I made.

Fail, and you're a traitor. Succeed, and you're the Son of Heaven.

Ma Sanbao's words echoed in my ears. So did what he'd said at the end.

Dark Heaven. I know about the people throwing Murim into turmoil. Probably far more about them than you imagine, and in far greater detail.

What exactly did he know? How had he learned so much? What connection was there between the information he'd uncovered about Dark Heaven and the Son of Heaven, and how dangerous was it?

I'd wanted to stop Ma Sanbao, who seemed determined to leave, and press him for more answers. But I held back, imagining the Embroidered Uniform Guard receiving a Buster Call[3330] and rushing over the moment I caused a commotion.

Or maybe I'd let him go because I was still trying to grasp the weight of what he'd said afterward.

Reward. A reward…

I turned the word over in my mind.

Ma Sanbao had been clear. If I helped them enthrone Prince Shangshan as the new Son of Heaven, they would give me a fitting reward.

And since he'd mentioned Dark Heaven first, it wasn't hard to guess what he meant.

The imperial family—the Great Nation—helps the Murim Alliance wipe out Dark Heaven.

People didn't say the government and Murim must not interfere with each other for nothing. The Great Nation had never involved itself deeply in Murim's affairs.

No, looking at things now, the reason was obvious.

It never had a reason to.

[3330] A reference to *One Piece*, in which a Buster Call summons a large-scale military attack.

There was no need to count the forces across the entire world. A million elite troops were stationed near the imperial capital alone, and I'd seen hundreds of Peak masters with my own eyes.

And if you included the forces that hadn't yet come to light—especially the Supreme Peak masters…

The imperial capital alone is already far stronger than the Murim Alliance.

Of course, most of the Great Nation's strength was concentrated there.

All the wars, including invasions by foreign peoples, had ended long ago. The emperors of a unified dynasty had no reason to give the City Lords and vassal princes scattered across the land more military power than they needed.

They had simply watched from atop those enormous, solid walls.

Watched the fierce struggle for power inside another enclosure, the one people called Murim, which stood within the Great Nation's own borders.

Even during the Great Faction War, they had watched.

But if that Great Nation took the Murim Alliance's side…

The scales of victory would tip in an instant.

Until now, the fight had been between the Central Plains' Murim and Dark Heaven. If the Great Nation joined in, Dark Heaven would become an external enemy hated by all under heaven.

I still couldn't gauge Dark Heaven's full strength. But the weight carried by the words "Great Nation" was immense and undeniable.

There was, of course, one fatal problem.

What if we failed?

High risk. High reward.

Fail, and you're a traitor. Succeed, and you're the Son of Heaven.

I felt as though I were standing at the edge of a cliff.

I could gain the Son of Heaven's wings and soar above the clouds. Or the Son of Heaven could break both my legs and send me tumbling over the edge.

Not just me. Everyone.

Snore.

…

Right. Including this idiot.

"…Mujin. You little shit."

Hyuk Mujin opened his eyes naturally and spoke.

"I wasn't asleep."

"Is that so?"

"Yes."

"Then why were you snoring so damn loud? The Embroidered Uniform Guard will be up here to haul you away soon. Your snoring woke the Emperor."

“I’m serious.”

“How are you going to prove it?”

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes darted around before he answered.

“I’ll stake Hong Jin’s balls on it.”

…

This idiot was trying to stake something that didn’t exist.

Before I could think of a reply, a familiar metallic sound came from outside the window.

Clack. Clack.

Orderly movement. A sharp aura.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Hyuk Mujin stared at the golden-armored guards entering the pavilion and asked, wide-eyed,

“Did the Emperor really wake up because of me?”

…

Should I really kill him?

I let out a deep sigh.

“Go bring His Highness Prince Shangshan.”

It looked like the time had come.

Chapter 869

After hurrying Hyuk Mujin upstairs, I blocked the Embroidered Uniform Guards who had come to the pavilion at the crack of dawn.

Then I flashed a broad smile at the first familiar face I spotted.

“Oh, fancy seeing you again.”

So much for the old saying that nobody spits in a smiling face.

Jeong Hogun didn’t so much as twitch an eyebrow, even when I waved at him like an old friend.

“Where is His Highness Prince Shangshan?”

I shrugged. “He was asleep until just now. Before a bunch of rude bastards barged in at the crack of dawn.”

“It is already the hour of the Rabbit. That is by no means early in the imperial palace.”

The hour of the Rabbit meant five to seven in the morning.

I was itching to explain children’s rights to this man, who was built like a Stone Golem, but when in Rome, you did as the Romans did.

Though, of course, it was the Son of Heaven’s will—above every law in the Great Nation—that had set the Embroidered Uniform Guard in motion so early.

“What brings you here?”

“I have no obligation to tell you.”

“Then let me guess. Is it finally time for the brothers to reunite?”

At that, Jeong Hogun reacted. His eyebrow twitched so sharply I could see it from where I stood.

“His Highness Prince Shangshan is to have an audience with His Majesty the Emperor.”

“Right. In four characters: a reunion of brothers.”

“You’re a lawless thug from the martial world, so it seems you can’t understand. This is not merely a reunion between brothers. It’s…”

“Oh, I get it.”

I nodded with a solemn expression.

“A somewhat complicated reunion of brothers. Right?”

“…”

“Not quite? Too long? How about a chaotic reunion of brothers? One character shorter, but pretty much the same thing.”

Jeong Hogun took a deep breath, as if trying to calm himself, then spoke in a stiff voice.

"…You'd be wise to watch that insolent mouth of yours before you bring down trouble you can't handle."

"Whoa, are you warning me? Didn't you hear your commander promise our prince yesterday that nothing like that would happen?"

"That was…"

"Judging by your face, you just remembered. If you understand, then let's do better from now on. Don't go making trouble for no reason. Okay?"

I smiled and patted Jeong Hogun's armor. Behind him, killing intent rose like a heat haze from the Embroidered Uniform Guards standing like iron towers.

Whoosh.

Now, that was some atmosphere.

Maybe I'd gotten under their skin more than I needed to. But in my experience, people like him only showed even a hint of what they were thinking when you provoked them like this.

Just like now.

"You don't want to cause trouble either, do you? Especially when you're this tired. Isn't that right, Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

What?

"You look rather tired. As if you didn't get much sleep last night."

Anyone with half a brain could tell Jeong Hogun hadn't tossed out that remark without a reason.

I looked into his calmly lowered eyes and the blade hidden in them, thinking to myself:

Well, look at this guy…

From the start, he'd given me the strong impression that he knew something.

But the deeper you thought, the longer you stayed silent—and that only gave your opponent more reason to suspect you.

Knowing that, I made a show of furrowing my brow.

"You need to feel comfortable to get any sleep. Could you sleep soundly with a bunch of menacing men surrounding you on every side?"

"They are not surrounding you. They are guarding His Highness Prince Shangshan."

"Does the imperial palace write 'guard' but pronounce it 'surround'?"

"That isn't worth answering."

"Then don't answer. Oh, while we're on the subject, let me ask you something else…"

I scratched the back of my head and went on.

"In this imperial palace ruled by His August Majesty the Emperor, what exactly are you guarding His Highness from?"

"…!"

"No, the more I think about it, the stranger it gets. If you're guarding him, there are already soldiers everywhere. I don't see why the Embroidered Uniform Guard needs to keep watch this closely, too. And if you're surrounding him, that makes no sense either."

Checkmate. A perfect one, too.

Either answer would leave him in an awkward position.

If he said they were guarding the prince, then as I'd said, there was no reason for all this. If he said they were surrounding him, that would be as good as admitting that the Embroidered Uniform Guard was monitoring Prince Shangshan on the Son of Heaven's orders.

Faced with an essay question that led to a dead end either way, Jeong Hogun chose silence.

Getting under the skin of someone who'd run out of things to say was my specialty.

"I asked you something, but you've gone quiet."

"…"

"If it were Baek Yeon, I bet he'd give me a straight answer. Are you keeping your mouth shut because you haven't made the rank yet?"

"…"

"People really have to get ahead in life. When's your next promotion? Do you get annual leave or sick days? If I cause trouble, does that mess up your performance review?"

"…"

"Honestly, you were surprised when your commander suddenly killed one of his subordinates yesterday, weren't you? Is he always that reckless? I won't tell anyone, so just whisper it to me. My earlobes are sensitive, though, so whispering's a little awkward. Just use Sound Transmission once."

Thrilling. Always fresh. Getting under someone's skin was the best.

I had no idea who'd won this year's Ballon d'Or,[3331] but I wasn't about to miss out on the Mouth d'Or.

I let my tongue run wild, trying to pry out as much information as I could, and needled Jeong Hogun relentlessly.

I started with gossip about his superior, Baek Yeon, then moved on to promotion woes, a working person's headache. I asked about the Embroidered Uniform Guard's average salary and overtime pay, then about what kind of hazing culture they had.

In short, I went after everyone but the Emperor.

[3331] The Ballon d'Or is an annual award recognizing leading football players.

Jeong Hogun held out far longer than I'd expected. He finally opened his mouth after I asked whether the Embroidered Uniform Guard's chow was any good—and started digging into his family tree.

"That's enough… Give it a rest."

I could feel his superhuman patience in the one breath he took between words. I nodded with a touch of respect, then replied,

"So you're still an unmarried bachelor, then?"

"…!"

"Don't get me wrong. I'm not criticizing you for being unmarried at your age. I mean, I'm not your parents. And staying single isn't so bad—you won't ruin someone else's life. So don't let it get you down. Keep your pecker—no, your shoulders—up…"

"You son of a bitch!"

To be precise, the shout I heard just then didn't come from Jeong Hogun.

One of the Embroidered Uniform Guards under him, whose face had been changing colors like a seven-hued rainbow for a while now, had finally lost his temper and charged at me.

Or, more accurately, he took one step forward before someone stopped him.

Thud.

"Enough. I won't say it twice."

A calloused palm stopped the guard's golden armor in its tracks. The voice that followed was low and heavy.

The guard recognized the hand as belonging to the very superior I'd just insulted.

"Thousand Captain! How can you let that bastard—"

Whack!

One punch, delivered with a heavy yet swift movement—brief, precise, and ruthlessly efficient.

Jeong Hogun's fist caught the Embroidered Uniform Guard squarely on the jaw. The man crumpled without even a groan, and I let out a quiet sound of admiration.

Not for Jeong Hogun's impressive technique, though.

"Wow. You really didn't say it twice."

"Obeying those above you—that is the law of the military that sustains the Great Nation, and the rule of the Embroidered Uniform Guard."

Jeong Hogun handed the subordinate he'd knocked out to the other guards, wiped the blood from his hand, and continued.

"The Commander promised no harm would come to you. For this once, I will follow that order as well."

"For this once?"

"Any order can be withdrawn depending on the circumstances. There are no exceptions."

His voice was as blunt as ever, but the gaze he fixed on me was bleak and wild, like the storm that had raged through the night.

It was a side of him I hadn't seen on the way to the Imperial Capital or after we'd arrived.

His composure had slipped. My guess had been right.

"Well, the situation hasn't changed yet, so I don't think that order's been withdrawn."

"Is that what you think?"

"Of course."

At my casual reply, Jeong Hogun closed the distance and leaned in to whisper.

"I'm warning you in all seriousness… If you try anything foolish in this imperial palace, where His Majesty the Emperor resides, you will not escape the consequences."

"Anyone listening would think I'd already pulled something."

"From the hour of the Ox[3332] to Insi.[3333] Three red lanterns were lit."

What?

"From what I've heard, the East Depot used secret signals like that. Probably."

My heart gave a hard thump.

From the hour of the Ox to Insi. Exactly when Ma Sanbao had come to see me.

And red lanterns as a signal, too.

It was lucky Jeong Hogun wasn't looking me in the eye while whispering in my ear.

Otherwise, I might have betrayed myself with the tiniest movement.

But I'd been through a lot by now. I'd learned how to keep my emotions in check.

I steadied my breathing and pulse quietly, in an instant, without anyone noticing. Then I gave a short laugh.

"Hong Jin's crazy about the color red. You can tell by how he paints his lips that color every day, right?"

"Yeah, I can tell. He used to belong to the East Depot, after all. He must have needed to call in someone who could help, even if it meant using such an outdated secret signal."

Was it suspicion, or certainty?

After countless thoughts flashed through my mind like streaks of lightning, I reached a single conclusion.

A trap.

Neither Hong Jin nor Ma Sanbao was careless.

[3332] The hour of the Ox is the traditional two-hour period from 1 to 3 a.m.

[3333] Insi is the traditional two-hour period from 3 to 5 a.m.

No—in terms of thoroughness, they were easily in the top five of everyone I'd ever met.

The imperial palace, the East Depot—only people like that could survive in places like these.

And if the secret signal was obvious enough for Jeong Hogun to figure out, there was no way they'd risk meeting while using it.

I can't take the bait.

I reached all those conclusions in an instant.

My next move followed just as quickly.

Tap.

I pushed Jeong Hogun away from where he stood right up against me, then curled my lips into a smile as naturally as I could.

"Fuck, you're writing a whole damn novel."

"…"

"To hell with the East Depot. I don't know anything about that. I got tangled up in something complicated and spent a while thinking it over. If you really don't believe me, go ahead and try to frame me."

No physical evidence. No witnesses.

It was a trap.

Jeong Hogun stared into my eyes, which didn't waver in the slightest. His answer was practically decided already.

"The night was unusually noisy. A fierce storm and thunder kept roaring without letup."

"So?"

"It means nothing. That's all."

Was the look in those black eyes suspicion he still couldn't let go of?

Or disappointment because his attempt to sound me out had failed?

For once, I couldn't tell for sure, and I wasn't given time to try.

"Have you been waiting long?"

Step. Step.

Three people came down the stairs, their footsteps accompanied by a familiar, androgynous voice.

Jeong Hogun and the Embroidered Uniform Guards immediately straightened and saluted the young prince, who had just appeared.

"I, Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, have come to escort His Highness Prince Shangshan."

Hong Jin, standing behind Prince Shangshan, who wore a tense expression, gave a wry smile.

“You’re still as impatient as ever. No, perhaps I should say you’ve waited longer than expected, since you did manage to hold out for an entire day.”

“Mind your words, Deputy Military Commissioner.”

“How frightening. Then I’ll…”

“You cannot come with us.”

Jeong Hogun cut Hong Jin off coldly, then added something I hadn’t expected.

“His Majesty the Emperor summoned only His Highness Prince Shangshan and Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Those two alone.”

What?

Chapter 870

For a moment, I doubted my own ears.

What did I just hear?

To be honest, even after arriving at the imperial palace, I hadn't really thought I'd get to meet the Son of Heaven.

It was only natural.

He ruled this vast continent, a man above all others.

Compared to him, I was a lawless thug from the martial world without so much as an identification plaque, and merely a son of the unimpressive Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Whatever standing I held in Murim, however much the Jin Family of Taiyuan had grown, none of it meant anything before those two words: Son of Heaven.

This was the imperial palace, and he was the Emperor, with civil and military officials and countless subjects under him.

And yet the Emperor, born of the dragon's blood and having seized the realm through rebellion, had summoned me to an audience even Hong Jin wasn't allowed to attend.

Could this be the world's lamest hidden-camera prank?

I swallowed hard, then checked that I was still in working order.

I picked at my ear with my pinky, slapped my cheek two or three times with my palm, and steadied my breathing before I finally spoke again.

"Say that again."

"What?"

"Say it again. Every last word."

Jeong Hogun looked at me in silence, then answered without complaint.

"I said that only His Highness Prince Shangshan and Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been summoned by His Majesty the Emperor."

Judging by his stony expression, this definitely wasn't a hidden-camera prank. I fell silent for a moment, faced with this unexpected reality, then asked again.

"Is this a dream or something?"

Jeong Hogun replied calmly.

"You slapped yourself just now. Pretty hard, too."

"I did."

"Did it hurt?"

"It did."

"Then it isn't a dream."

"I see."

The second silence lasted a little longer. The first to break it wasn't me, but Hong Jin.

"Why?"

"I don't know."

Jeong Hogun gave a brief answer, then added, "We of the Embroidered Uniform Guard merely follow His Majesty the Emperor's orders. We need no reasons, and we ask no questions."

Of course, that was easy for the Embroidered Uniform Guard to say. They were government officials. My situation was a lot more complicated.

Why is he summoning me all of a sudden?

I had a bad feeling about this. No—I could already feel a chill at the back of my neck.

Why was I thinking of Jeong Hogun's manner, which suggested he had some idea what had happened last night, and Ma Sanbao's face as he spoke of rebellion?

I felt a chill run down my spine and parted my lips.

"What if…I refused the invitation?"

Contrary to what I expected, Jeong Hogun answered as though it were no great matter.

"Do you have a reason to?"

"I haven't been feeling well lately. Besides, like I said, I didn't get much sleep last night."

"If you're ill, then there's no helping it."

"Oh. Really?"

"Of course. We'd best move you to a different residence while we're at it."

"No, I appreciate the thought, but I'm fine. There's no need to go that far…"

"Guards. Contact the Ministry of Punishments at once. Tell them to prepare the most spacious accommodations."

"Huh?"

I blinked at Jeong Hogun.

Then I thought about it for a moment.

Was that *hyeongbu* the kind of brother-in-law a younger sister called her older sister's husband?[3334] If so, was Jeong Hogun the continent's first transgender Imperial Guard? If not…

"Um. That Ministry of Punishments…"

"It's nothing to worry about. Merely an institution for carrying out punishments, administered by the Embroidered Uniform Guard."

"…"

[3334] *Hyeongbu* is pronounced the same as the Korean term for the Ministry of Punishments and a woman's term for her older sister's husband.

That's a pretty fucking big thing to worry about. Shit.

I glared at Jeong Hogun, who didn't so much as twitch an eyebrow, then held out my hand toward Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

"Shall we go, Your Highness? I'll escort you."

As I followed the Embroidered Uniform Guard out of the pavilion, I heard Hyuk Mujin mutter with relief.

"Phew. Glad it wasn't me. I really thought I was getting hauled off."

You little shit.

The imperial palace was far bigger than I'd imagined.

Several times larger than the Forbidden City I'd toured with a VR headset on a school field trip.

The one saving grace was that the Embroidered Uniform Guard had the decency to prepare a palanquin.

"Please get in, Your Highness."

"Huh? What about mine?"

"I'll have to contact the Ministry of Punishments again."

"…"

Of course, there was no palanquin for me. Only Prince Shangshan, a member of the imperial family, got to enjoy the luxury of riding in a four-man sedan chair carried by four Embroidered Uniform Guards.

"We're moving."

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

At Jeong Hogun's order, a golden current surged forward at tremendous speed.

I stayed close beside Prince Shangshan's sedan chair, ready for anything, and took in every corner of the imperial palace.

Couldn't hurt to know the layout.

Thinking about the worst-case scenario was one of my old habits.

Where each building stood, how many soldiers guarded it, and how strong they were.

If what awaited me wasn't the Son of Heaven but a forest of spears and blades, I needed to find the fastest, most efficient escape route.

Especially if I had someone else with me.

—Your Highness.

At the Sound Transmission I sent discreetly, Prince Shangshan gave a small jerk.

But it lasted only an instant. I sent another Sound Transmission to the young prince, who had quickly regained his composure.

—It's unlikely, but…if the worst should happen, you must leave everything to me. Do you understand?

Prince Shangshan was just about to give a small nod when I noticed Jeong Hogun, running at the head of the procession with his eyes fixed ahead, starting to turn his upper body.

I spoke a beat before he could.

"What are those people?"

Fortunately, my timing was perfect.

Half a beat later, Jeong Hogun glanced toward Prince Shangshan, then followed the direction of my finger.

Splash. Splash.

With every step, blood mixed with rainwater that had yet to dry.

Surrounded by another group of Embroidered Uniform Guards, dozens of bloodied men were being dragged somewhere. Jeong Hogun saw them and answered.

"You can see for yourself. Prisoners."

"Anyone can see that. I asked what they did."

"Those men belong to the Imperial Astronomical Bureau. Or rather, they used to."

"The Imperial Astronomical Bureau?"

"It's the institution that observes and analyzes the heavens. They'll be punished for failing to predict last night's lightning and torrential rain."

"…!"

"Don't waste any more time on something so irrelevant. His Majesty is waiting."

I answered with a silent nod, but the sight of the prisoners' backs, already receding into the distance, wouldn't leave my mind.

These people are seriously insane.

They'd beaten men half to death just because they hadn't predicted the weather.

That seemed far too brutal to write off as the way things were in this era.

No. Even for this era, that's not normal.

Once I started looking at things differently, I noticed more.

Even as I hurried along behind the Embroidered Uniform Guard, I studied the expressions of the palace attendants, whose faces I hadn't paid much attention to before.

Their faces and movements were stiff as wooden dolls. Whenever their eyes flicked toward the soldiers stationed all around them, I could see a tremor they hadn't managed to hide.

Everyone is afraid.

By the Emperor's will—or even by a single word from him—someone could be tortured or killed.

No matter how brave they were, they wouldn't dare refuse or show their displeasure.

This was the imperial palace, where not even the smallest mistake could be tolerated. The Emperor had taken the throne by killing countless high officials and even his own blood relatives. His power must be absolute.

The cold, oppressive atmosphere I could feel against my skin wasn't something I could explain away as merely the product of an age ruled by absolute monarchs.

Rule by terror.

A wise and benevolent ruler embraced people with kindness as vast as the sea.

A tyrant drove them with spears and fear into a thorny enclosure of his own making.

I'd heard plenty of stories about such rulers, though I'd never encountered one myself. Even so, I had a good idea what kind of person the current Son of Heaven was.

And the biggest problem was…

I'm going to meet that tyrant of my own free will.

Out of habit, I felt inside my clothes and found the small bundle of pills made by the Divine Physician.

Oddly enough, remembering their unbelievably foul stench made me feel a little better.

If—if I had to fight here, what would happen?

Whether I should call it reassuring or not, based on what I'd seen so far, the Embroidered Uniform Guard stationed in the imperial palace numbered in the thousands, perhaps as many as ten thousand.

That alone was enough to make a great army. Still, compared to the combined forces in the Imperial Capital and its surrounding areas, they might as well have been fairies.

The real issue is the Supreme Peak masters loyal to the Emperor. And the System is unavailable because of the update.

Not being able to use the System was an enormous penalty.

With the System down, I couldn't gain EXP, let alone recover by leveling up.

On top of that, my Inventory—which had served me so well whenever I caught enemies off guard with an unexpected attack—was firmly shut.

If I'd known this would happen, I should've taken White Flame out of my Inventory the last time I logged out in Murim. Or at least the Fire Dragon Armor.

I'd only been able to fight as recklessly as I had because I could level up. And I'd beaten masters in higher realms than mine thanks in large part to my Inventory and divine weapons.

But…right now, I had nothing.

No System to save my life in a dangerous moment. No divine weapons.

All I had was a bundle of pills that even the neighborhood mongrel would spit out, and a body that would get worse unless I forced those rotten-smelling things down.

Oh, and I had a few other things, too.

A young prince and a eunuch I had to protect. And some damn idiot with a bad snoring problem.

Perfect.

At this point, I was almost tempted to ask Prince Shangshan to assassinate the Son of Heaven. I called out to Jeong Hogun, who was walking silently ahead of us, just in case.

"Hey, can I ask you something? Ever heard of *chokbeop sonyeon*[3335]?"

"Chokbeop what?"

"*Chokbeop sonyeon*[3336]."

"What's that? Never heard of it."

"…Never mind."

Now that I thought about it, people were being implicated by association and killed one after another. What good would being too young for criminal prosecution do here?

I pictured a sweet little fantasy that could never come true.

The Emperor, collapsed in a pool of blood. Embroidered Uniform Guards rushing in from every direction at the sound of a scream. And Prince Shangshan, grinning triumphantly with a dagger in his hand.

"Your Majesty! Your Majesty!"

"Yep. Killed my imperial brother, didn't I?"

"Your Highness Prince Shangshan! What have you done?"

"The Embroidered Uniform Guard can't do a thing, can you? Now I'm the Emperor, right?"

"His Majesty has been assassinated! Apprehend the traitor Zhu Bao at once!"

"Yep. I'm still too young to be prosecuted!"

"…"

It was a sweet fantasy, but now that I thought about it, it seemed pretty serious in its own way.

Becoming Emperor because he was too young to be prosecuted.

If this were a Western fantasy setting, wouldn't they call him Brat the First?

"Jin Taekyung. Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Ah, it's nothing."

[3335] *Chokbeop sonyeon* is a Korean legal term for a child too young to be criminally prosecuted.

[3336] *Chokbeop sonyeon* is a Korean legal term for a child too young to be criminally prosecuted.

I couldn’t exactly tell Prince Shangshan what I’d been thinking. I was trying to dodge his question when it happened.

Vrrrrmm.

The air shook violently.

With an oppressive weight like ten thousand *geun*[3337], two middle-aged men who looked exactly alike appeared and blocked our procession.

“Stop.”

“Stop.”

The twins, identical in face and build, spoke in unison. It looked a little ridiculous—but I didn’t laugh.

Supreme Peak masters.

No doubt about it. This place was a demon-slaying battleground.

[3337] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

Chapter 871

Even the Embroidered Uniform Guard, called the Emperor's hands and feet alongside the East Depot, apparently had its limits.

Jeong Hogun led Prince Shangshan and me over to the middle-aged twins, whose names I didn't know, and sent us a brief Sound Transmission.

"From now on, be careful with every word and every move. Otherwise, you won't leave here alive."

Who the fuck did that bastard think he was kidding?

I could already feel the danger on my skin. Not just from the twin Supreme Peak masters who'd appeared out of nowhere, but from all the people inside Qianqing Palace whose presence I could sense before we'd even entered.

This place is guarded like hell.

My mouth felt as gritty as if I'd swallowed sand. I drew on my internal energy slowly enough that no one would notice, then moved my lips.

"Just answer me one thing. Why was I summoned?"

"I told you I don't know."

"Do you really not know, or do you know but refuse to tell me?"

"Both."

Damn it. I was an idiot for asking.

I glared at Jeong Hogun, who stood there with his usual impassive face, then passed beneath the plaque reading Qianqing Palace alongside Prince Shangshan, who had climbed down from his palanquin.

Step. Step.

Our footsteps rang out unusually loudly.

I quietly sized up the twins' backs as they walked in perfect sync, their movements identical down to the smallest detail.

They've definitely trained in a combined attack technique…but what martial art, exactly?

No matter how I looked at it, the situation was bad.

Not being able to guess what martial arts they'd learned was one thing. Just imagining two fully accomplished Supreme Peak masters using a combined attack technique made my stomach hurt.

And on top of that…

Why the hell are there so many bats?

Shadows hidden even in the faint light.

The people watching our every move from the darkness had to be guards raised by the imperial family—and assassins.

If the worst happened, those assassins, nearly a hundred of them, would carve me up with the one-strike killing techniques they'd spent their lives honing. And the twin Supreme Peak masters would be right there with them, wielding a combined technique they looked as if they'd learned in the womb.

Unless you're one of the Ten Kings—or maybe a master on par with the Three Saints—you'll almost certainly be buried here.

People say the martial world is a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords.

But they're wrong.

This was the real mountain of sabers and forest of swords. A place where the Emperor alone decided who lived and who died.

How many masters does he have under his command?

Even the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families had two Supreme Peak masters at most. Usually, they had only one. And here the Emperor had two of them working as gatekeepers.

I felt as though I were walking along a blade's edge.

A bead of cold sweat slid down the back of my neck. Then I noticed a small hand tugging at my sleeve.

Squeeze.

The hand gripped hard enough to crumple the fabric. Only then did I notice the young prince's ragged breathing.

He's trembling.

Before he was a member of the imperial family or a prince, he was a child.

He'd been one when I first met him, and he still was now.

He'd said he left the imperial palace when he was too young to remember. Of course he wouldn't remember the Son of Heaven, either.

And now his only family, his one and only older brother, is threatening his life.

A thought occurred to me.

Maybe the cheerful side Prince Shangshan had shown on the way to the Imperial Capital was his way of hiding his fear and disappointment.

When Hong Jin warned him that the Son of Heaven was a threat and he shook his head, saying that couldn't be true…maybe that was the only choice a child could make when faced with a reality too hard to believe.

He shouldn't have to understand any of this…but he's had to grow up far too soon.

My feelings grew complicated.

I thought of the boy from that winter in Shanxi Province, when icy winds howled through the mountains. He'd lost his parents and climbed a hill with his tiny, fern-like hands clinging tight to his little sister.

And I remembered young Hayeon patting our mother's back as she lay facedown, sobbing at our father's funeral.

Damn it.

I bit my lip hard to hold back a sigh.

Murim and the modern world had nothing in common. They were completely different worlds.

But there was one thing that never changed.

People.

That was why I, who'd once thought all of this was a game, had started accepting Murim as another reality.

They were people, after all. They got angry, felt joy, and grieved.

There were evil people who deserved to die, and good people with eyes as clear as glass.

I'd killed the former without a moment's hesitation. When it came to the latter, I'd even risked my life to help them.

And now I felt sorry for this young prince.

His trembling breaths reminded me of the young siblings who'd lost everything and fled after Jopil's attack. His small hand clutching my sleeve made me think of my own little sister, Hayeon.

I need to think about this coldly. I have to. I can't afford not to…

But no matter how much I thought about it, I wasn't sure I could.

If I had to choose between treason and submission, could I really leave this child behind?

Could I look back on it years later as if it meant nothing?

Man, he really knows how to make things difficult.

I smiled bitterly and looked down at Prince Shangshan, who didn't even reach my chest.

Then, almost on impulse, I raised a hand and gave his head a couple of gentle pats.

"…!"

His eyes flew wide, and his lips parted as if he were about to shout that I'd overstepped my bounds. But Prince Shangshan only stared up at me in surprise, his mouth working soundlessly.

Instead, his grip on my sleeve loosened, as though he felt relieved.

Who had ever dared to pat this child on the head?

Even something as simple as that—something other children his age took for granted—was probably unfamiliar to Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao.

And right now, this little bit is the best I can do for him.

Just then, the twins, who had been striding forward without hesitation, stopped before a massive door.

Click. Rumble.

An iron door swung open with a heavy rumble. A dragon was carved into its surface so vividly it almost seemed alive. The twins, who hadn't said a word since we entered the palace, broke their silence.

"Please enter."

"Please enter."

It wasn't as though we had any choice left. Still, hearing that we'd be separated from those Supreme Peak masters was welcome news.

I nodded, then stepped through the iron door ahead of Prince Shangshan, shielding him as I went.

Rrrr. Thud.

The heavy door shut behind us with another rumble. Beneath the faint light of countless night-shining pearls glowing on the ceiling, a man stepped forward.

Step.

His build was as slight as his footsteps were light.

He looked about fifty and wore a long robe with sleeves that dragged along the floor. Prince Shangshan spoke first when he saw him.

"Who goes there?"

Who goes there? Who goes there? Who goes there…

His tense voice echoed again and again through the empty corridor. Not another person in sight—not even an ant.

The middle-aged man gazed at the tense-faced Prince Shangshan and at me, standing slightly in front of him to shield him. Only when the echoes had faded did he speak.

"To see His Highness Prince Shangshan grown so tall, and from so close, fills me with deep emotion after all these years."

After a moment's hesitation, Prince Shangshan asked, "Do you…know me?"

"Of course. Though Your Highness does not remember me."

A faint smile touched his wrinkled lips. He turned his gaze from Prince Shangshan to me.

"You and I have never met."

I said nothing. The moment I saw him, I'd had to fight to keep a string of curses from spilling out.

Why? Simple.

The middle-aged man in front of me—no, this middle-aged man *too*—was a Supreme Peak master.

Oh, for fuck's sake… I can't do this anymore.

This was only my second day at the imperial palace.

And even that was being generous. I hadn't actually been here for twelve

shichen,[3338] a full day.

Yet this was already the fifth Supreme Peak master I'd come face-to-face with.

I'm so screwed.

I was seriously wondering if I should start wearing a condom instead of clothes when the man spoke again.

"You needn't tell me who you are. I already know. Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Damn it. There was no way around it now.

I let out a deep sigh and answered.

"Does everyone around here recognize me wherever I go?"

"The imperial family's eyes and ears are everywhere. And you do stand out."

"Because I'm handsome?"

"No. Because you look like a thug at first glance."

Listen to this guy.

"Then what are you around here? The eyes? Or the ears?"

"Hmm. Which do you think I'm closer to?"

"The cleaning crew."

"What?"

"Your sleeves are dragging on the floor, so I figure you must be great at mopping."

The middle-aged man stared at me blankly for a moment, then laughed aloud.

"Ha ha. Just as I'd heard."

"Heard what? Are the rumors already spreading?"

"I told you—there are eyes and ears everywhere. Everyone who needs to know already does. They've heard that some audacious martial artist dared to set foot in the imperial palace and has a knack for making people laugh."

"That's strange. I usually get under people's skin more than I make them laugh."

"I forgot to mention that 'making people laugh' was a considerably toned-down version of what I'd heard."

"…"

"Of course, the accounts were all over the place, so I was curious myself. Now, this way."

Before I could answer, he turned and took the lead as if it were only natural, without so much as a glance back.

"Where are we going?"

"Interesting question. Have you forgotten why you came here?"

I'd had my suspicions, and I'd been right.

[3338] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours.

Apparently, this old guy was the third transfer point on our way to the Emperor—and the final guide who would take us to our destination.

Obviously, he isn't a cleaner.

Who the hell was he? His clothes offered no clue.

East Depot? Or Embroidered Uniform Guard?

His gaunt frame made him look more like a eunuch, but his voice was so weighty it could knock even an Embroidered Uniform Guard off his feet.

And he moved around as naturally as if this were his own home.

Even the twins didn't come this far. So he must be one of the Emperor's closest, most trusted confidants…

According to Ma Sanbao last night, the young Emperor was hot-tempered and suspicious. Only a handful of high-ranking officials and trusted servants who'd proven their loyalty were allowed into his residence, Qianqing Palace.

And that wasn't all.

There were the guards, of course, along with the eunuchs and palace attendants who stayed inside to see to his every need.

This place existed for the Emperor, by the Emperor, and in service of the Emperor.

Could just anyone come and go in Qianqing Palace—let alone somewhere this deep inside?

I didn't know for sure, but he'd probably need to be close in standing to Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Then could this guy be the East Depot's leader, Cang Gong? No. I heard he was much older, and that he'd been bedridden with illness for years.

I racked my brain, but no one came to mind.

Ma Sanbao had mentioned far too many people, and this man didn't match the distinctive features of any of the few he'd described.

If only I could use my Qi Sense Skill right now…

But there was nothing I could do about that.

If you're thirsty, you dig a well.

I'd just have to pry the information out of him somehow.

I followed the man as he strolled along at an unhurried pace and tossed out a question.

"When do I get to meet the Emperor?"

"Soon."

"At this rate, we'll get there tomorrow."

The man gave a short laugh without looking back.

"You're as impatient as you look. Wait a little. His Majesty is enjoying a diversion he hasn't had in some time."

"A diversion? After summoning us?"

“And what, do you intend to complain?”

“…!”

“Everyone has their place. To ascend the throne is to be able to look down upon them all. A simple enough truth of the world, isn’t it?”

My expression hardened.

Not because I objected to the Emperor’s behavior, or because the man’s answer had struck a nerve.

It was the casual look on his face, his tone, the effortless authority in every small movement. And on top of that, his appearance didn’t match any of the Emperor’s confidants Ma Sanbao had mentioned.

No way.

The thought sent a groan through me.

Step.

The man came to an abrupt stop. Without a moment’s hesitation, he threw open the door before him, decorated with gold, silver, and jewels.

“Your Majesty. In accordance with your solemn imperial command, I have brought the two people you requested.”

But there was no answer.

In fact, there wasn’t a hint of anyone else’s presence.

Only one person stood inside the enormous bedchamber.

The middle-aged man.

He turned slowly toward us and smiled, showing his white teeth.

“It was a brief diversion, but I enjoyed it.”

“…!”

“…!”

A bolt of lightning shot down my spine.

Chapter 872

"It was a brief diversion, but I enjoyed it."

A shiver ran down my spine. At last, I knew who the middle-aged man was—the answer I hadn't been able to find no matter how hard I thought.

The Son of Heaven…!

The ruler of the continent, who governed all under heaven.

The man who'd seized the throne in a coup after bathing the Imperial Capital in blood a little over ten years ago.

I stared wide-eyed at the middle-aged man before me—no, at the Emperor.

How?

Everything that had happened proved who he was. The question came from what I already knew.

He should still be around forty.

When the young, ambitious fourth prince of the Great Nation launched his coup, he'd been no older than his late twenties.

A little over ten years had passed since then. At most, he should have just turned forty.

And yet…

Even being generous, he looks over fifty.

I couldn't write it off as a face that had aged prematurely. He was the Emperor, a man above all others, not some country bumpkin who had spent his life farming under the blazing sun. More than that, he was a Supreme Peak master. How could he look so old?

By comparison, the fact that the Emperor of the Great Nation was a Supreme Peak master wasn't all that shocking. As the fourth prince, he'd distinguished himself in battle time and again thanks to his exceptional martial talent.

Still, I hadn't expected it.

One person suddenly came to mind.

Ma Sanbao. The East Depot's second-in-command, who'd spent the past decade and more serving as the Emperor's right hand while hiding his own rebellious ambitions.

Did he know about this?

If Ma Sanbao had known, he would have told me long ago.

That left only one conclusion.

Even Ma Sanbao didn't know. No—that's not quite right. The Emperor must have deliberately kept it hidden.

A chill ran down my spine. Part of my conversation with Ma Sanbao the night before flashed through my mind.

“The Emperor is a sinister man who keeps his schemes close. You can see it in how he still uses the Embroidered Uniform Guard to keep the East Depot in check, even after all these years.”

“But isn’t the East Depot also the Emperor’s right hand?”

“Yes. More precisely, it was the late Emperor’s right hand.”

“…!”

“Do you know what all powerful people have in common? They suspect everyone, then suspect them again. I still haven’t learned how the current Emperor and Baek Yeon joined forces, but after the Embroidered Uniform Guard’s coup succeeded, the East Depot became something the Emperor had little use for but couldn’t simply discard. He handles all his affairs from Qianqing Palace and has kept himself shut away there for years.”

“Qianqing Palace?”

“The Emperor’s residence. It’s highly unlikely, but… if you ever meet him, mind your conduct. Think carefully before giving even the shortest answer.”

The Emperor had hidden the truth even from Ma Sanbao, who was the East Depot’s second-in-command in name and its leader in practice.

So why? Why show *me* this side of himself?

I couldn’t be certain of anything just yet, but at least some of what Ma Sanbao had told me that day was right.

The Emperor was sinister, and he kept his schemes close. The look in his eyes now, as though he could see straight into my heart, told me that much.

“Ha ha. You look rather surprised.”

His mouth smiled. His eyes didn’t.

After laughing at the sight of me standing there frozen, the Emperor spoke again, his voice low.

“Why? Do I look so different from what someone told you to expect?”

“…!”

For a moment, I couldn’t breathe. Through the air that had suddenly grown heavy around us, I could sense the Emperor’s intentions all too clearly.

He suspects me…

All the more reason to stay calm. I tried not to show what I was thinking.

“Yes.”

“What?”

“I’ve already heard a few things from Hong Jin—or rather, the Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province.”

“Hong Jin, Hong Jin. It’s been a long time since I heard that name.”

The Emperor gazed into the distance for a moment, as though recalling an old memory. Then his sharp eyes turned back to me.

"What did he say?"

"That Your Majesty distinguished yourself in martial arts early on and gained the throne before you turned thirty."

"And?"

"That was all."

"That can't be all."

Of course it wasn't all.

But how was I supposed to tell a man who had killed his own blood relatives to take the throne, "He said you were a fucking bastard"?

I couldn't simply insist that was all, either. Hong Jin was a loyal retainer the late Emperor had cherished enough to entrust with Prince Shangshan's care. The Emperor must have known long ago that someone like him wouldn't have warm feelings toward him.

I needed an answer that would allay the Emperor's suspicions without getting Hong Jin dragged off by the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

The question was whether any answer could do both.

Fuck, I don't know.

Sometimes you just had to close your eyes and take the plunge. I swallowed and opened my mouth.

"Actually, he did tell me more."

"Speak."

"Well, I can't say it myself."

"What?"

"If Your Majesty is curious, perhaps you could summon him later and ask him directly…"

The instant my voice trailed off—

Whoosh! Whoosh! Whoosh!

Sharp winds swept in from every direction. Dozens of black-clad figures dropped out of empty air and surrounded me, thrusting their weapons toward me.

Shhk.

Had they meant to do this from the start? Or had loyalty to the Emperor driven them to anger?

Blood welled where the keen blades had cut my skin, then rolled down my neck.

These bastards… They're serious.

The men left no gap in the circle around me. They had the blank indifference of butchers slaughtering livestock—and the deadly resolve to kill me the instant the order came.

At the same time, a hand gripped my sleeve tightly.

Squeeze.

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

The young prince had been frozen since the moment he learned the middle-aged man was the Emperor. I gave him a smile, hoping to reassure him.

The Emperor had been watching us in silence. Suddenly, he shook out his voluminous sleeve.

Flap.

As the fabric billowed, the black-clad men withdrew their weapons and sprang into the air. They vanished into the Emperor's quarters as though melting into them, leaving only the faintest trace of their presence. Their concealment technique was almost a divine skill.

"Your Majesty's men are certainly loyal."

This time, I wasn't being sarcastic.

At my genuine admiration, the Emperor answered dryly.

"Loyalty isn't all they have. They're no match for the Slaughter Saint you're close to, of course."

"…!"

"What? Did you think I wouldn't know even that much?"

I fell silent. This time, I really was surprised.

Everyone under heaven knew the title Slaughter Saint, but only a tiny handful knew that he'd reappeared after vanishing long ago.

Yet the Emperor knew not only that he was back, but that he and I were connected. He must have learned it through the vast intelligence network he had spread across the continent.

"Did the Embroidered Uniform Guard tell you?"

Displeasure and interest mingled on the Emperor's face at the question that slipped out of me.

"You have remarkable nerve, asking me that."

I had somehow survived the last exchange. There was no sense in provoking him further. Sensing the line I'd crossed, I lowered my head.

"I'm sorry."

"I stand in fear and awe, Your Majesty."

"Pardon?"

"Not *sorry*. You should stand in fear and awe, as everyone does before me."

Both characters in *hwanggong*, the phrase he demanded, meant fear. It was the highest expression of deference to an Emperor whose authority knew no bounds.

He kept staring at me after he finished speaking. I tried again.

"I stand in fear and awe, Your Majesty."

"Better. You're a lawless thug from the martial world, so I can't expect much. But from now on, you can learn one thing at a time."

A faint smile spread across his wrinkled lips. My stomach twisted.

But…

First, I have to survive.

I wasn't the only one in danger. Everyone's lives depended on what I said and did.

That included the young prince whose trembling hand still clutched my sleeve.

Just then, the Emperor's gaze, indifferent until now, finally settled on his only younger brother.

"Come here."

The trembling against my sleeve stopped at once.

Prince Shangshan hadn't regained his composure. He had gone rigid as a statue.

"Do you intend to make me say it twice?" the Emperor asked quietly.

"…!"

Prince Shangshan looked at him with trembling eyes, then raised his head to look up at me. He drew a ragged breath, released my sleeve, and stepped toward the Emperor.

No—he threw himself down in a full prostration and bowed.

"I-I, your subject, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, pay my respects to Your Majesty, my imperial brother."

A heavy silence settled over the room. It lasted a moment, or perhaps much longer.

The Emperor looked down at Prince Shangshan, his eyes too deep to read. His face was so cold that it was hard to believe he was looking at his much younger brother.

Then he spoke.

"How old are you this year?"

"T-Twelve, Your Majesty."

"You have good Muscles and Bones. Have you trained in martial arts?"

"Yes."

"We brothers devoted ourselves to martial arts from childhood. Only our eldest brother took more after a civil official."

Prince Shangshan drew a small breath. As he grew older, Hong Jin must have told him bits and pieces about his family. But hearing it from his only brother carried a different weight.

Especially when that brother was the Emperor of the Great Nation—a man he could never treat like an ordinary sibling, and the enemy who had sent their family to their deaths.

"I… see."

"Taizu, our grandfather, founded the Great Nation through martial force, too. It's part of the imperial family's tradition. Looking at you, it seems blood really does tell."

The Emperor added in a dry voice, “Whether that proves a poison or a boon, I cannot say.”

“…!”

“…!”

I barely held back a groan.

Even before we reached the Imperial Capital, I’d guessed that the Emperor’s intentions toward Prince Shangshan were anything but friendly. Still, his reaction to the prince was alarmingly blatant.

Is he really that wary of a brother so much younger than him?

Power was ruthless.

People fought like beasts over the little wealth they had, even with their own parents and siblings. What would it be like over a vast continent, an entire empire?

Even so, the Emperor’s suspicion of his youngest brother, a boy of twelve, was terrifyingly thorough.

And, in a way, well-founded. People led by Ma Sanbao were already dreaming of rebellion.

The Emperor’s next words were proof that his wariness had passed the point of no return.

“From now on, I’ll look after you.”

“…!”

Chapter 873

The same words can mean different things depending on who says them and the circumstances.

The Emperor's words were no exception.

"From now on, I'll take care of you."

"…!"

At the unexpected words, Prince Shangshan jerked his head up from his prostration. I couldn't stop a groan from slipping through my lips.

"Mm."

That was probably why the Emperor's gaze shifted from the prince at his feet to me.

"Do you have something to say?"

Plenty.

But the man before me ruled the continent. I lowered myself onto one knee and answered as politely as I could.

"If I may be so bold, Your Majesty."

"If you think it's bold, you'd be wise to keep it to yourself. Assuming you want to keep your head attached."

"…!"

"Still, very well. Go on. It might be interesting to see how much my patience has grown over the past ten-odd years."

Those in power often dressed their whims up as patience.

Just like now.

He's really enjoying this.

I lowered my head slightly as I watched the Emperor's eyes gleam like a child who'd found an amusing new toy. I was trying to hide the way I'd clenched my teeth without realizing it.

Just how far did that arrogant Emperor's patience extend? If I crossed some invisible line he'd drawn, could I bear the consequences?

Questions like those suddenly flashed through my mind, but right now I had to do whatever I could to fend off the Emperor's grasping hand reaching for Prince Shangshan.

Stay calm.

I took a small breath and slowly spoke.

"Your Majesty's offer is truly gracious, but His Highness Prince Shangshan is already well cared for by his loyal subjects. In fact, he may not need anyone to care for him anymore."

“Your manners have improved all of a sudden. You’re still far from skilled at hiding the barbs in your words, though.”

The Emperor gave me a mocking look and continued.

“Tell me, who are these loyal subjects you spoke of? That devious eunuch? Or that martial-world ruffian who flouts the Great Nation’s rules of propriety and roams the land?”

Even a stray dog would know the first meant Hong Jin and the second meant me.

But I didn’t so much as flinch. I bowed deeply and answered.

“Your Majesty is right that I belong to the martial world. I have roots in my family and my martial school.”

“So you are not my younger brother’s subject. Then what gives you the right to wag that tongue of yours in front of me?”

“Though I am not his subject, I was summoned as His Highness’s guest, and Your Majesty gave me permission to speak.”

“This is getting more interesting by the moment. But dress a beast in clothes, and does that make it a person? Don’t waste my precious time on pointless formalities that don’t suit you. Get to the point. Briefly and simply.”

Briefly and simply.

That was music to my ears.

But now was the time to bow once more, just in case. I looked down at the soft carpet and said,

“How could I do that?”

“Fifteen minutes should be enough.”

“Pardon?”

“For those fifteen minutes, I’ll forgive whatever rudeness you commit. Speak freely. That is my imperial command.”

Good.

With that safety net in place, I finally raised my head and looked at him. Then I said what had been on the tip of my tongue all along.

“You already know, don’t you?”

“What?”

“His Highness Prince Shangshan has grown up well without Your Majesty’s care. He has managed without it until now, and he’ll continue to.”

“…!”

The instant the Emperor’s eyes flashed—

Whoosh!

Killing intent like invisible blades shot in from all sides and wrapped around me.

It was the killing intent of dozens of imperial guards—or rather, assassins—who had already revealed themselves once before. They'd all sent it at me at the same time.

Their martial skill was at Peak, but their abilities as assassins had reached Supreme Peak.

If they unleashed the one-strike killing techniques they'd spent their whole lives honing, staking their lives on them, even I wouldn't get away unscathed.

But what I feared never happened.

Before their sword light could fall on me, the Emperor raised a hand and stopped them.

Shff.

The darkness on all sides rippled.

Holding back the assassins who seemed ready to drop from the air and carve me to pieces, the Emperor gazed at me through narrowed eyes.

"Prince Shangshan doesn't need my care?"

"Yes."

"Do you not know he's only twelve years old?"

"I do."

"Then how can you say that?"

"Because that twelve-year-old boy shouted at the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard—a man whose authority could bring down even birds in flight."

"…!"

"If someone had told him to do it, then His Highness would still be a child in need of care. But no one there advised him to do so."

Prince Shangshan had decided for himself and acted without hesitation.

I didn't know whether he'd been born with that resolve or his circumstances had gradually taught it to him, but it was a mark of adulthood.

At thirteen, he'd already shown he could do something even adults who'd merely grown older with the years they'd been given could not.

"Deputy Military Commissioner Hong Jin, who has been with him for so long, treats His Highness like a child, just as Your Majesty does. But I see it differently. When I was a child, I couldn't even have dreamed of doing something like that."

"Of course not. You weren't a member of the imperial family, or a prince."

I shrugged.

"I happened to meet one member of the imperial family. I can say with confidence that His Highness Prince Shangshan is ten times more mature than that person."

"An imperial relative? You mean Ju Wongong?"

"You know about him, too."

The Emperor even knew about the Slaughter Saint.

I didn't know how deeply he'd dug into my affairs, but the fact that I was involved with one of the few members of the imperial family probably didn't even count as noteworthy information to him.

The mention of Ju Wongong made him frown.

"Everything ultimately comes from status and authority, not age. If this boy were no more than a distant imperial relative like Ju Wongong, do you think he could have shouted at Baek Yeon so boldly?"

"I've heard there's nothing more pointless than arguing about something that never happened. Besides, making the most of what you've been given isn't something a child can do, either."

The Emperor clicked his tongue at my ready answer.

"That tongue of yours is quite slick."

"It's one of my signature skills."

"But can that signature skill defeat an imperial command?"

"Pardon?"

"What if I issued an imperial command right here and now to revoke Prince Shangshan's assigned territory in Shanxi Province, grant him the title Marquis Within the Passes, and keep him by my side?"

"…!"

This son of a bitch fights dirty even in an argument.

An imperial command isn't some fucking Spirit Bomb.[3339]

I swallowed the curses threatening to burst out and asked, "If you did that, what would become of His Highness?"

It might have crossed a line. A ruffian from the martial world had no business asking about that, and the Emperor could have shouted me down with that very argument.

But the Emperor answered readily, like a judge watching to see how far I'd cross the line.

"He'll return to where he belongs. He'll live in the imperial palace, study under excellent teachers, and be served by loyal palace attendants in surroundings far better than barren Shanxi Province."

"Would Hong Jin be among them?"

"I said *loyal* palace attendants. Not a devious eunuch like him."

The Emperor was right about one thing and wrong about everything else.

The imperial palace was where Prince Shangshan belonged. But his teachers and attendants would all be the Emperor's people.

And…

They'll watch his every move for the Emperor and do whatever he orders.

[3339] The Spirit Bomb, or *Genki Dama*, is an attack in *Dragon Ball* that gathers energy from others.

Even if that order were to assassinate him.

The thought left my mind cold.

“If I may ask, Your Majesty, why are you going this far?”

The Emperor’s lips curled with amusement.

“Because it’s only natural.”

“Natural?”

“I’m his older brother. Do I need another reason to look after my one and only younger brother?”

“Of course not. I just find it a little strange.”

“What do you find strange?”

“Why Your Majesty, who hasn’t cared for that one and only younger brother in over ten years, would suddenly decide to act like an older brother now.”

Clang! Clang! Clang!

In an instant, before any order had been given, the assassins appeared again and packed themselves around me.

A growling voice came from behind one pitch-black mask.

“Do you truly want to die?”

I didn’t answer. I looked at the Emperor, whose expression I couldn’t read, and spoke evenly.

“The fifteen minutes aren’t up yet.”

“You bastard!”

“Your Majesty made the promise yourself. You said you’d forgive any rudeness for fifteen minutes. I’ve only followed your imperial command and spoken honestly.”

“Shut that foul mouth of yours! How dare you—”

Slice.

Cold and burning pain struck at once. Blood ran down my neck from a wound deeper than the one already there.

“Your Majesty!”

Prince Shangshan had been frozen like a statue until now. Seeing the assassins surround me, he cried out to his one and only older brother.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan is my guest and my friend! Spare him! Please forgive his rudeness!”

Thud! Thud! Thud!

I had no time to stop him. Still prostrated, the young prince struck his forehead against the ground again and again. I bit my lip. The Emperor looked down at him with cool arrogance, then suddenly spoke.

“Enough.”

Everything stopped at that one word.

The dagger inching into my neck stopped. So did Prince Shangshan, who had been begging for my life.

His forehead red, the prince lifted his head to look at his brother. The Emperor spoke slowly.

“That man dared to insult me. Even if I made a promise earlier, he crossed the line by a wide margin.”

“Y-Your Majesty…”

“But the fact remains that I made that promise myself. An Emperor cannot go back on his word. Isn’t that right, Third Shadow?”

The assassin called Third Shadow had been pressing his dagger against my throat as though ready to cut it at any moment. He fell silent.

“You’re slow to answer.”

“…I am humbled, Your Majesty.”

“I clearly made a promise. Yet you disobeyed my command and tried to harm him.”

“Your Majesty, that was—”

“First Shadow. Carry it out.”

Slice. Shhk!

With a sharp cutting sound, the dagger pressing into my neck slid away.

Another masked man dropped from the air and, without the slightest hesitation, cut Third Shadow’s throat. Then he prostrated himself before the Emperor.

“I have executed him.”

“…!”

“…!”

The air in the vast chamber froze.

I wiped Third Shadow’s blood from my face and stepped in front of Prince Shangshan, who was breathing in short, shallow gasps. This time, no one stopped me.

No—they couldn’t.

The master who held their lives in his hands had given no order.

You fucking bastard.

I glared at the Emperor, my eyes blazing.

“Your Majesty.”

“This time, you’d better choose your words carefully. The fifteen minutes I promised you are already up.”

“…!”

“And I’ll give you one last chance.”

“A chance?”

“Yes. A chance. I hear you’re Prince Shangshan’s friend.”

The Emperor laughed softly.

“You’ll never meet again after this, so say your final farewells. That is the last act of kindness I’ll grant you.”

Shff.

The moment he finished speaking, the assassins began closing in from all sides. I looked at them and understood.

There was no longer any way to protect Prince Shangshan here.

The Emperor had won.

Chapter 874

Perhaps the outcome had been decided long ago.

The imperial palace, a perfect enemy stronghold. A guard so tight that even “ironclad” didn’t do it justice. And the Emperor, ruler of all under heaven.

He had taken charge of the stage, the actors, and the direction himself. Even if a character like me stepped into the scene, it probably wouldn’t change much.

A thought struck me.

Perhaps all of this was a kind of amusement to the Emperor.

Why else summon me along with Prince Shangshan when he had no need to see me? Why brush aside words that could have gotten me branded a traitor on the spot?

And why look at my rigid face now and sneer?

Crack.

A bone shifted with a sound from my tightly clenched fist. I scanned the impassive eyes visible above the assassins’ pitch-black masks, weighing my options.

What do I do?

The Emperor’s little game was daring—and supremely confident.

Naturally, everyone in our party had been forced to surrender their weapons on entering the palace. But beyond that, no restrictions had been placed on me.

Perhaps he was confident that no one under heaven could harm him.

If so, he’d made a clear mistake.

Even barehanded, I was a superhuman who had opened my Middle Dantian, an heir to the Fire Gate Clan who had inherited the Fire King Jeok Cheongang’s fearsome fist and palm techniques.

All I have to do is take their weapons.

With every shift of my gaze, a path invisible to anyone else took shape in my mind.

A path to kill the assassins as quickly and efficiently as possible, then escape with Prince Shangshan.

The fact that the Emperor was a master who had entered the realm of Supreme Peak was unexpected, but that was all.

He’s only just entered Supreme Peak. What if I’m willing to sacrifice an arm to capture him first?

If I took the Emperor hostage, it would all be over. The Great Nation was one enormous mechanism, and the Emperor was both its master and its most important part.

With him in my hands, I could neutralize not only the assassins in here but also the twin masters waiting outside.

Perhaps even Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

But… what then? What happens after that?

Once I started, there would be no going back. That would be the beginning of a true rebellion.

If I took the Emperor hostage and fled Qianqing Palace, would the East Depot, led by Ma Sanbao, help us? Were the people who had signed the collective pledge he'd mentioned the night before fully prepared?

As thoughts tangled through my mind—

"Your servant, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, will obey the will of my most august elder brother, Your Majesty."

Prince Shangshan bowed deeply before his one and only elder brother—the Emperor, who stood above all others—and cried out at the top of his voice.

"Long live the Emperor! Long live the Emperor! Long, long live the Emperor!"

"…!"

My heart lurched.

Was it because Prince Shangshan's sudden action had broken the tension gripping my whole body?

No.

It was because I could read the desperate plea in that young prince, so small he didn't even reach my chest.

Don't step in any further.

It was as if a voice I couldn't hear, a voice that couldn't be heard, had sounded in my ear.

Prince Shangshan was trying to stop me. He had stepped forward before I could make a choice that couldn't be undone.

The Emperor looked down at him with an arrogant gaze.

"…You've certainly grown."

He murmured it with an unreadable expression, then swept his sleeve. Prince Shangshan, who had been crying "Long live" and bowing again and again, understood the gesture and rose.

"Do you truly intend to obey my will?"

"Of course, Your Majesty."

"That sounds as though it isn't your own will. You may refuse if you don't want to."

That was what he said, but his narrowed eyes suggested otherwise.

Prince Shangshan lowered his head without a word. Unlike before, his answer was perfectly calm.

"It is my will, too."

"I'm overjoyed that we brothers are of one mind."

"I am deeply honored."

Prince Shangshan seemed to have accepted what was happening. At the sight of his calm face, the tension drained out of me. I steadied my breathing.

It's no good.

Prince Shangshan had made the right choice.

The answer was clear. We had to retreat when we weren't prepared.

At least for today.

The Emperor watched me and smacked his lips, then suddenly spoke.

"Now that you've decided, there's no need for further discussion. This audience is over. Everyone, withdraw."

"As Your Majesty commands."

The assassins hoisted Third Shadow's body onto their backs and melted into the darkness. Then the Emperor added,

"No Shadow. You too."

Shff.

The air rippled in answer. I barely held back a groan.

This is insane.

A Supreme Peak master whose presence even I hadn't sensed.

No—a Supreme Peak assassin.

That was probably why the Emperor had been so untroubled about letting me into his chambers without imposing any serious restrictions.

He'd been testing me to the very end.

I revised my judgment of the Emperor at once.

He wasn't merely arrogant and daring. He was more meticulous and suspicious than anyone.

If you succeed, you're the Emperor. If you fail, you're a traitor.

I hadn't thought far enough ahead. When he was still known as the Fourth Prince, he had drawn his sword, swung it once, and overturned the Imperial Capital to seize the Great Nation.

Such boldness and decisiveness were beyond anything an ordinary person could dream of.

The thought suddenly crossed my mind: if I'd made a move, I would never have left Qianqing Palace alive.

Damn it.

Was this the power of the Emperor? The power of the Great Nation?

Was my best option really to withdraw so helplessly, unable even to protect a young prince?

"Let's go."

At Prince Shangshan's quiet murmur, I turned away to hide my gritted teeth.

The Emperor had finished his game and vanished behind the fluttering silks.

Rumble.

A massive iron door, out of place in such a splendid chamber, slowly opened. Beyond it stood dozens of palace attendants I hadn't seen on the way in.

"We greet His Highness Prince Shangshan."

"We greet His Highness Prince Shangshan."

They bowed to Prince Shangshan with utmost deference. Every one of them was a striking beauty.

Each had the kind of looks said to topple kingdoms.

But one woman standing a step ahead of the rest caught my eye at once.

"Please call me So Gyo."

So Gyo. That was her name.

Her voice was calm, and her eyes shone like the morning star. Even apart from her beautiful features, there was something unusual about her.

"By His Majesty's solemn command, we have been assigned to serve His Highness Prince Shangshan. We humble women will attend to you from now on, so please do not worry."

It was simple enough to understand why none of the people assigned to accompany the prince were heavily armed Embroidered Uniform Guards.

They've trained in martial arts. And to a considerable level, too.

Every one of them had the internal energy of a First Rate master.

I also recognized the thin belts at their waists for what they were: flexible swords.

And I couldn't help guessing that if the Emperor gave the order, they'd be ready to drive those blades into Prince Shangshan's neck at any moment.

There's no time.

I was getting anxious. I had to meet Hong Jin as soon as possible and make a plan. I had to see through the Emperor's hidden intentions, to discern his scheme.

"Your Highness."

Prince Shangshan lifted his head at my call. He looked at me with calm eyes. Whether that calm came from composure or resignation, I couldn't tell. Then he turned to So Gyo.

"I'd like you to give us a moment."

Working as a palace attendant in Qianqing Palace meant that they, too, were among the Emperor's many loyal servants.

But after a moment's thought, So Gyo quietly led the others away through the maze of corridors.

Only then did Prince Shangshan manage a smile.

"Speak. Though we may not meet again for some time, understand that the circumstances aren't right for a long farewell."

There was something about a child who had grown up too soon that brought a lump to your throat.

But I couldn't let my emotions take over.

I swallowed the words rising to my throat and held out my hand.

"First, take this."

"…?"

"Come on. There's no time."

Prince Shangshan hesitated, then took what I offered. When he saw the small, glimmering object in his palm, his eyes widened.

"This is…"

"A gift from me."

He examined it curiously.

"It's the ring you always wear."

Prince Shangshan couldn't know or even guess its proper name: the Myriad-Poison Ring.

A divine artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan, and one of the divine weapons Dark Heaven had targeted.

Unlike White Flame and Fire Dragon Armor, which I usually kept in my Inventory, this was a ring I always wore, just in case.

"Why would you suddenly give this to me?"

"I thought you might need it, Your Highness. You looked at it with interest several times on the way to the Imperial Capital."

It was true. We'd spent a long time in the carriage, and Prince Shangshan had taken an interest in everything I owned.

Even this ring, too clunky for the women of this era and awkward for a man to wear.

A few days ago, he'd even pestered me to give it to him.

"About that ring."

"Hm? Oh, this one?"

"Yes. The one you're wearing. Would you give it to me?"

"Um, sorry, but that's a little difficult. Have you always been interested in accessories?"

"No. I just want something of yours."

"Oh, collecting keepsakes…"

"What was that?"

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

"At any rate, I'd like to have it. Of course, I'll pay you handsomely."

“I’m sorry. I can’t give this to anyone, and I couldn’t sell it for any amount of money.”

“Why not? Is it so precious that you’d refuse even my request?”

“Well, you see… Right. It was my father’s keepsake.”

“Oh.”

“It means a lot not just to me, but to the whole family. My eldest brother still cries whenever he sees this ring.”

“I believe your father is still alive.”

“…Now that you mention it, I think it was my mother’s keepsake. I was mistaken.”

The Myriad-Poison Ring was never supposed to end up in anyone else’s hands.

In the end, Prince Shangshan had been disappointed, and I’d promised to sign about five thousand autographs when we returned to Shanxi Province.

Back then, I hadn’t had the faintest idea what awaited us in the Imperial Capital.

“Are you really giving this to me?”

“Not for good. You have to return it later.”

“Didn’t you say it was your mother’s keepsake?”

“Uh. Well, you see…”

Just as I ran out of things to say, Prince Shangshan let out a quiet laugh.

“I already know you were lying.”

“Ah.”

“I’m a little disappointed that you’d lie even to me, but it’s all right. You must have had your reasons. It must be that precious.”

I smiled along with him.

“That’s right. It’s very precious, so always keep it where no one else can see it…and make sure you return it.”

He was an old soul in a child’s body. He understood what I meant.

Prince Shangshan hesitated as though he didn’t know what to say, then nodded firmly.

“Mm. I understand. I promise.”

Only then did I feel a little more at ease.

The Emperor had seized the throne through a coup more than a decade ago, earning countless enemies in the shadows and no shortage of condemnation.

The Emperor cared enough about having a legitimate pretext to summon Prince Shangshan to the Imperial Capital before bringing him under his control. If he meant to kill his one and only younger brother, the most likely method was poison.

As long as Prince Shangshan keeps the Myriad-Poison Ring on him, poisoning him won’t be an option.

That would buy me time to find another way.

As I thought it over, I sensed the palace attendants slowly returning from farther down the corridor.

Our brief farewell was almost over.

“It’s time for me to go,” Prince Shangshan murmured, his voice subdued.

I bent down to meet his eyes.

“We’ll meet again soon.”

“I hope so. Then I’ll be able to repay the debt I owe you.”

“Your Highness.”

“Yes?”

“Don’t you know? Friends don’t owe each other anything.”

“…!”

“Still, if you insist on giving me something, I’ll accept it gratefully.”

I grinned and ruffled Prince Shangshan’s hair.

The young prince stared blankly at me with wide eyes, then smiled, too.

Chapter 875

The farewell was brief.

Before long, the palace attendants returned. They surrounded Prince Shangshan and led him away through Qianqing Palace's vast, maze-like corridors.

For now, this is the best I can do.

I thought to myself as I watched the young prince's back, glimpsed now and then between the attendants.

How much time did that child have left?

I didn't know.

If I'd gained anything from this audience, it was confirmation that the Emperor wasn't a complete madman who would stop at nothing.

His coup has already made him plenty of enemies. He can't get rid of his youngest brother the same way.

Everything needs at least some pretext.

Even in an era of absolute monarchy, with the Emperor ruling over all, that was no exception. And the Emperor, who'd brought a bloody storm to the imperial palace more than a decade ago, had dangers lurking out of sight.

Old retainers who longed for the late Emperor.

And common people who pitied the young prince.

If Prince Shangshan died under unnatural circumstances now, it would give someone a pretext for another rebellion.

Poisoning would look the most natural…but it won't be easy.

No one knew exactly how far the Myriad-Poison Ring's power extended.

But it was a rare treasure that had even absorbed the Formless Ultimate Poison that once spread through Jeok Cheongang's body. Even the Emperor wouldn't have an easy time obtaining poison of that caliber.

Unless he eventually discovered the Myriad-Poison Ring and took it by force.

But I've bought us some time, at least.

Did I regret leaving the Myriad-Poison Ring with Prince Shangshan?

No.

From everything I'd seen so far, the Emperor and Dark Heaven were definitely connected somehow, and if the imperial family fell into their hands, it was all over.

I had to protect Prince Shangshan, even at the risk of losing the ring.

He was the anti-Emperor faction's only hope, the one person who could hold it together.

And he was one of the friends I'd made here.

Though there's a bit of an age gap for me to call him a friend.

I smiled bitterly and watched until Prince Shangshan and his party disappeared from sight.

When I turned away, heavy-hearted, a woman stood quietly watching me. I still wasn't used to seeing her, but her face was the sort I'd remember for a long time after a single meeting.

"Have you been waiting long?"

So Gyo answered calmly. "No. This humble woman is carrying out His Majesty the Emperor's orders. What does it matter whether the wait is long or short?"

Can't fault her loyalty.

I gave an awkward nod. "Then let's go."

The Emperor's order So Gyo had mentioned was to guide me out of Qianqing Palace.

Of course, "guide" was a polite way of saying she was watching me and kicking me out. But what did it matter?

"I'll lead the way. Please follow me."

I'd barely taken a few steps after her when I frowned.

"Wait. I don't think this is the right way."

"It is. You remember the way we came."

Of course I did. I'd made a point of checking my escape route in case the worst happened.

"Don't just say it is. I'm telling you we're going the wrong way."

"The way into Qianqing Palace is different from the way out."

"What?"

"The life gate can become the death gate, and the death gate can become the life gate. Since you're a martial artist who travels the martial world, Young Master Jin, I thought you would understand what that means."

"…!"

I fell silent. A word flashed through my mind like a bolt of lightning.

"Don't tell me…mechanisms and formations?"

So Gyo gave a slight nod and started walking again. I stared after her for a moment before hurrying to follow, still reeling from what she'd told me.

Damn it. Even for an Emperor, this is ridiculous. This isn't a residence. It's an impregnable fortress.

There were no fewer than three Supreme Peak masters stationed in Qianqing Palace, not counting the Emperor.

One was a master of the concealment technique who guarded him at close range. And even by a conservative estimate, more than a hundred elite assassins were stationed throughout the palace.

On top of all that, mechanisms and formations?

He's definitely not normal.

Naturally, an Emperor needed tight security. But there were limits.

The defenses here were abnormal, as though they reflected the Emperor I'd met just moments ago.

Maybe he was afraid, too. He made so many enemies.

They said thirty thousand people had been dismembered or beheaded during his coup.

Among them were his own blood relatives in the imperial family, founding heroes who had laid the foundations of the Great Nation, upright officials, and renowned scholars.

All of them had died.

Killed in a coup that defied the natural order, on the command of a single man.

It would have been absurd if an Emperor like that *didn't* have enemies.

Then could it be…?

As I followed So Gyo, I thought of him not as the Emperor who stood above all others, but as a Supreme Peak master.

His formidable martial prowess. His face, which looked ten years older than it should have—no, a good twenty years older for a man so young and so skilled.

Was that why?

Supreme Peak was a lofty realm no one could enter through innate talent alone.

And yet the ruler of the continent, who had everything anyone could want, had sweated blood to learn martial arts.

He must have swung weapons without pause, like the martial artists of the martial world he called ruffians. At times, he must have groaned under pain that racked his whole body.

Even so, it seemed he had never entirely shaken his fear of assassination or his nightmares.

It's only a guess, but it's certainly possible.

I'd taken countless lives with these hands. I thought I could understand a little of what he felt.

There was no such thing as a justifiable killing. Only a killing with a pretext.

I'd comforted myself by saying I'd had no choice, that they were people I had to defeat. But that didn't change the truth.

The countless dead would come to torment me from time to time—maybe even quite often—and I'd wake up drenched in cold sweat.

So what must it be like for an Emperor who'd killed tens of thousands in a coup with no pretext at all?

His nights must be a real inferno.

I smiled bitterly and kept walking. So Gyo led me onward without a word, deeper into passages I couldn't make sense of.

I was starting to get a bad feeling.

"Um, can I ask you something?"

So Gyo stopped and turned around. At the same time, she spoke without hesitation.

"It's all right."

"What?"

"I mean that nothing unfortunate will happen to you, Young Master Jin. Please follow me."

I was quiet for a moment, then clicked my tongue.

"Right to the heart of it. Did you learn to read minds?"

"No. I noticed that your breathing had become slightly uneven."

"Oh. I gave it away, huh? You're perceptive."

"I've learned martial arts as well. Few things matter more to a martial artist than controlling one's breathing."

She was right. The higher a master's realm, the more likely a fight was to be decided in less than a breath.

But that didn't change how pointed she sounded. As I watched her turn away, I thought, *Is she picking a fight with me?*

Probably. No, almost certainly.

It was absurd for So Gyo, who was First Rate at best, to lecture me. I let it pass with a silent chuckle.

She was one of the Emperor's loyal servants, and I was in enemy territory. What else could I expect?

I should be grateful she isn't attacking me.

There was no point arguing. I shook my head and was about to start walking again when—

Crash.

"…!"

The sound was faint, but I heard it clearly. It came from somewhere in a dark corridor beyond one of the paths branching off like a crossroads.

Then I heard an irritated voice.

"You lowly wretches! How dare you…!"

"Please follow me."

So Gyo hurried over and blocked my path. Ignoring her, I drew up my internal energy and sharpened my senses.

A woman. That was definitely a woman's voice.

Something was going on. Something I didn't know about yet.

And if I wanted to accomplish what I'd come to do in this damn imperial palace, I needed every clue I could get.

Step.

"Young Master Jin!"

Her low shout reached me the moment I stepped toward the darkness. She glared at me, her cold eyes carrying an unmistakable warning.

That only made me more certain. If she was this determined to stop me, there was something outsiders must never see.

But this was the Emperor's residence. I put on an innocent smile and pretended not to understand.

"It sounded like something happened. Shouldn't we go take a look?"

"I told you to follow me."

"Come on. The imperial palace isn't very friendly, is it? Who was that just now? Sounded like a woman to me."

"That's enough. I've warned you."

"One warning means I'm still fine for now, right? But seriously, who was it? I'm so curious I might not sleep tonight."

"Better that than sleeping forever."

Her face set, So Gyo suddenly cried out, "Come out!"

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

In an instant, a dozen or so blades dropped from the high ceiling and surrounded me.

Black masks as dark as the shadows, with the eyes of killers visible above them.

Surrounded in a flash by the assassins of Qianqing Palace, I spoke in a low, heavy voice.

"You said nothing unfortunate would happen."

So Gyo put a hand on the flexible sword at her waist. "It won't. As long as you turn around and leave quietly."

"I just looked because I heard a strange noise. Why are you so touchy?"

"Should I take this to mean you intend to defy His Majesty's will?"

"That would be a problem."

"Then turn around and follow me. Quietly."

"And if I don't?"

Ssshhh.

I silently drew up my internal energy.

Perhaps it was the weight of my aura bearing down around them, or perhaps they expected a bloody fight. Either way, So Gyo and the assassins' faces went cold as ice. I looked them over one by one, then quietly raised both hands.

"Fine. I surrender."

"…!"

"Just finish showing me the way. I need to get back and eat."

So Gyo let out a small sigh and dismissed the assassins. I watched them withdraw and smiled to myself.

There was no need to invite any more danger here.

Though I'd been stopped in no time, I'd already accomplished what I'd set out to do.

I'd heard that woman's sharp cry clearly.

And it reminded me of someone's voice I'd heard a few months ago at the residence of the City Lord of Sichuan Province.

It had been so sweet and dripping with seduction that I couldn't have forgotten it.

What was her name…?

Right. Aehyang.

The beloved concubine the Emperor had taken from the City Lord of Sichuan Province.

Chapter 876

Hong Jin stared hard at the golden armor blocking his way.

His voice, usually as high and gentle as a woman's, had sunk lower than anyone had ever heard it.

"Move."

"Impossible. You cannot take a single step beyond this place."

"I said move."

"Sir! Deputy Military Commissioner!"

"Do you really think you can stop me? You lot dare?"

"…!"

The several dozen Embroidered Uniform Guards looked at one another, their faces stiff.

They already knew the eunuch standing before them was no pushover.

They said no matter how high you climbed, power never lasted ten years, and no flower stayed red for ten days. But things were different when you were talking about the East Depot's former Investigating Eunuch, who had once enjoyed the late Emperor's favor.

Besides, plenty of old officials still remained at court, and Hong Jin surely had ties with them.

Whether those ties were friendships forged as fellow servants of the late Emperor or secrets he'd seized while holding sway over the East Depot, no one could say. But one thing was certain.

His influence was not to be underestimated.

"Even after more than ten years away from the palace, a few letters are enough to send a low-ranking Embroidered Uniform Guard to the borderlands. So get the hell out of my way, if you want to keep wearing that shiny armor."

A cold flame flickered in Hong Jin's eyes.

It had been two shichen[3340] since his young lord left to meet the Emperor.

The eunuch, renowned even within the East Depot for his cool head, was already at the end of his patience.

If I'd known it would come to this, I should've done whatever it took to go with him.

Something had clearly happened.

He tried to suppress the unease that kept rising inside him, but even that was getting harder to do.

Just as Hong Jin bit down hard on his lip without realizing it—

"Everyone, calm down. Take it easy."

[3340] A shichen is a traditional time unit lasting approximately two hours. Two shichen are about four hours.

A breezy voice cut in out of nowhere. Hyuk Mujin stepped in front of Hong Jin and waved the Embroidered Uniform Guards down.

“Try to be understanding. It’s taking a while, so he’s worried.”

“Martial artist Hyuk!”

“Come now, Comrade Hong, you should calm down too. What did these people do wrong? We underlings do what we’re told, whether they say ‘get down’ or ‘bark.‘ Right?”

The Embroidered Uniform Guards frowned, unsure whether he was taking their side or calling them sons of bitches to their faces. Hyuk Mujin didn’t give them time to think it over.

“Still, could you at least find out what’s going on? We’re tired enough as it is. If you make this difficult, nobody’s going to have a good time. Right?”

“Wait. That’s…”

“Oh, you’ll check? Wow! The Embroidered Uniform Guard! The pride of the Great Nation! The guardians of the imperial family! Thanks a fucking lot! If you get the time, drop by the Hyuk Family Textile Shop in the center of the Imperial Capital. Give them my name and you can get a discount.”

There was no chance to reply. Without waiting for the guards’ answer, Hyuk Mujin turned, grabbed Hong Jin, and hurried him away.

He spoke in a low whisper.

“There’s nothing to gain by provoking them right now. You know better than most, so why are you doing this? Get a grip.”

Those words didn’t make Hong Jin’s unease disappear, but they were enough to remind him of the reality he’d briefly forgotten.

Hyuk Mujin was right.

If he used his remaining influence at court to move a few powerful figures, all he’d manage to do was get rid of a few hunting dogs.

He wouldn’t touch the body, let alone the head. Reaching the owner holding the hunting dogs’ leashes was out of the question.

Now was the time to hide his claws and sheath his fangs.

Of course, though his head had cooled, his heart was still pounding wildly.

“Aren’t you worried, Martial artist Hyuk?”

At Hong Jin’s sudden question, Hyuk Mujin tilted his head.

“Sorry? About what?”

“You don’t feel any particular loyalty toward His Highness Prince Shangshan. I know that. It’s the nature of martial artists, so I have no intention of criticizing you for it. But…”

“Oh, you mean I’m not worried about what happened to the Captain who went with him?”

Hong Jin nodded weakly, and Hyuk Mujin answered at once.

“Of course I’m worried. I am.”

“Then how can you be so calm?”

“This is the best I can do.”

“What?”

“I’ve followed the Captain through all kinds of trouble. Whenever he’s stepped in to handle something himself, he’s found a way to settle it.”

“…!”

“No matter how badly things got tangled, in the end, the Captain swept it all away. All those bastards who strutted around claiming to be masters or secret masterminds went off to interview with Yama.[3341]”

Hyuk Mujin looked at Hong Jin’s wide eyes and continued in an unruffled voice.

“To be perfectly honest, I’ve never met anyone as strong as the Captain. He’s insanely strong.”

“Martial artist Hyuk, I’m sorry, but I’ll be blunt. The imperial palace is practically a living monster. No matter how skilled a Supreme Peak master Young Master Jin is…”

“I wasn’t just talking about martial arts.”

“…?”

“Not his martial arts. The man himself. He’s just a strong person, period. That’s the kind of person the Captain is.”

“…!”

“Even if the palace is crawling with masters a level or two above him, they still won’t be able to handle the Captain. It makes no sense, but that’s how the Captain I know has always been.”

“Does that make any sense?”

“It shouldn’t, but somehow it does. Isn’t that why you asked our Captain to look after His Highness Prince Shangshan?”

Hong Jin was struck speechless. Then he understood.

When he’d first received Ma Sanbao’s secret letter saying the Embroidered Uniform Guard was on the move, why had Jin Taekyung been the first person to come to mind?

Trust between them?

Of course that mattered. But if trust alone had been the deciding factor, he would have brought Li Feng, a lay disciple of Huashan and the Assistant Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province.

[3341] Yama is a Buddhist lord of the underworld associated with judgment of the dead.

Though Li Feng and Hong Jin had briefly been at odds, Li Feng had remained unwaveringly loyal to Prince Shangshan for years, even when the prince had been all but cast adrift.

Compared to that, calling Hong Jin's relationship with Jin Taekyung one of mutual trust was a little embarrassing.

It was true that he had a fairly close business relationship with the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

But why?

Why had he asked for Jin Taekyung when he could have brought a proven loyalist or another master from the martial world?

Hong Jin already knew the answer.

"You're right, Martial artist Hyuk. I'd foolishly forgotten for a moment. I let my emotions get the better of me."

Seeing Hong Jin regain his composure as if nothing had happened, Hyuk Mujin grinned.

"I understand. It happens."

"Young Master Jin… yes, he really is an unfathomable person. Most of what I've heard about him is hard to believe. Of course, some of the information I went to great trouble to obtain must be nonsense."

"Nonsense? What information?"

"Oh, that?"

Hong Jin gave a small laugh.

"You'd laugh your head off if you heard it, too, Martial artist Hyuk. Apparently, Young Master Jin caught a dragon in Dongting Lake."

"That's definitely a rumor. It was more of an imugi than a dragon."

"Thought so. I paid a thousand gold pieces for that information, and this is the kind of ridiculous…"

Hong Jin stopped mid-sentence.

After a breathless silence, he finally managed to squeeze out a few words.

"What did you just say?"

"Huh? What do you mean?"

"No, just now. You said it wasn't a dragon…"

"Oh. An imugi. That's right. I was there, too. At first I thought I was dreaming, but after a while I realized I wasn't. Well, it didn't fly through the sky, so it definitely wasn't a dragon. It was an imugi."

"…?"

"By the way, what piece of shit leaked that information? That was supposed to have been handled quietly, under the strictest secrecy."

"…!"

Still reeling as if time had stopped, Hong Jin realized that everything Hyuk Mujin had said earlier had been true. Every last word.

Choosing Jin Taekyung really had been a stroke of genius.

An imugi? He caught an imugi? A person caught an imugi? Wait, those things actually exist?

The shock was so great that, for a moment, he even forgot to worry about the young prince.

Just as Hong Jin stood frozen with his mouth hanging open, Hyuk Mujin, who'd been cursing the rumor-monger for some time, cautiously spoke up.

"Um, would you be willing to spend another thousand gold pieces? I saw a talking tiger when I went to Nanman recently…"

"Move!"

A shout rang out, carried on internal energy. It was a voice Hong Jin knew all too well.

Hong Jin whipped his head around. His eyes widened like saucers when he saw who it was, while Hyuk Mujin, who'd been trying to strike a quiet deal, cried out on instinct.

"I'm sorry! Please spare me! I didn't say anything! May the Captain protect me—long live the Jin Family of Taiyuan!"

"I'm back. I have something to tell you, so let's get inside… Hyuk Mujin, you little shit, what's wrong with you? Why is he acting like that?"

Hong Jin had been about to tell him about the talking tiger, but his heart sank.

Where is His Highness…?

No matter how many times he looked around, he couldn't see him.

His young lord. The Great Nation's last hope.

Hong Jin rubbed his eyes with his sleeve again and again, but only one person was coming toward him.

Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

So it's come to this.

Something had definitely happened. That cruel Emperor's hand had finally reached his lord.

But Hong Jin fought back the haze gathering before his eyes.

It wasn't over yet. Surely that young martial artist had found some way out.

And as if to answer Hong Jin's hopes, Jin Taekyung—who'd nearly knocked the Embroidered Uniform Guards, standing firm as iron towers, flying with a shoulder-check—moved his lips.

"Get inside the pavilion. Right now!"

Of course, he didn't forget to smack his one loyal subordinate on the back of the head in the moment he had to spare.

“Glad you returned safely…”

Whack!

“Ow!”

“Yeah, I’m back safe and sound, you little shit.”

Back at the pavilion, I used my internal energy to soundproof the place, then quickly laid out what had happened.

As briefly as possible. Just the essentials.

First. The Emperor had locked Prince Shangshan inside Qianqing Palace under the pretext of protecting him.

Second. That Emperor was shameless as hell. Like the rabbit in the old folktale[3342] who left his liver behind, he seemed to keep his conscience hidden somewhere else. Oh, and he was a Supreme Peak master who looked way older than he was.

Third. It seemed like the beloved concubine the Emperor had taken from the City Lord of Sichuan Province a few months ago was in Qianqing Palace.

That wrapped up my summary. Even the twenty-first-century summary junkies who treated their eyes and scroll wheels as mere decorations would’ve given it a passing grade. Hong Jin’s expression had changed with every point; now all that remained was unconcealable shock.

“The City Lord of Sichuan Province’s concubine… is staying in Qianqing Palace?”

“Yes. Almost certainly. But before I draw my own conclusions, there’s something I need to ask you.”

I took a deep breath and asked again.

“Is it normal for the Empress or the imperial consorts to stay in Qianqing Palace?”

“Not at all.”

“Even a consort the Emperor favors?”

“Not at all. The rules of the imperial family are strict.”

“Then…”

“That’s right. There’s only one explanation.”

Hong Jin and I met eyes. The next moment, we spoke at the same time.

“Pregnant.”

“With child.”

Fuck.

The Emperor seemed to have found a new heir for the Great Nation to replace Prince Shangshan.

[3342] In the Korean tale *Byeoljubujeon*, a rabbit escapes after claiming it left its liver elsewhere and must go back to retrieve it.

Chapter 877

It hadn’t made sense from the start.

These were members of the imperial family, not Chunshik’s family next door. Why would they all gather in Qianqing Palace and live together like one big happy family?

Besides, I’d been there. The place was closer to a fortress or a labyrinth than the Emperor’s living quarters.

Its passages twisted around like the Yeonsan Rotary in Busan. I wouldn’t have been particularly surprised to turn a corner and run into a Minotaur.

And that wasn’t all.

Assassins swarmed everywhere like Chinese cockroaches, and mechanisms and formations had been installed to deal with unwelcome visitors.

At that point, even the dungeon beneath the dormitory of some British school of magic would’ve looked like a five-star hotel.

But the Emperor couldn’t have created such a hopeless place simply because he was crazy.

He had a clear purpose.

Ironclad security.

That was why he’d stationed enough force there to stop any assassin from breaking through and filled Qianqing Palace with loyal servants he could trust.

And that security had held perfectly—until today, when some young ruffian fresh from Murim realized Aehyang was there.

Until he guessed one of the secrets the Emperor had tried hardest to keep.

Pregnant?

I felt as if someone had hit me in the back of the head with a sledgehammer. Across the table, Hong Jin and Hyuk Mujin looked just as stunned.

“Pregnant…? Is that true?”

“I can’t be certain yet, but it’s highly likely.”

Hong Jin answered Hyuk Mujin’s dazed question, then added quietly, “It would be best if all of this were utter nonsense.”

I nodded heavily.

To hell with family ties—the Emperor had seized the throne after practically bathing in his relatives’ blood.

If a child of his own blood were born under these circumstances, it was obvious what would soon happen to Prince Shangshan.

Pulling up the weeds by the roots.

The child who'd once had to leave the imperial palace in a rush, wrapped in swaddling cloth, had now grown into a proper young boy. And the seed of a towering tree, sprung from the same root, had taken hold and flourished.

That was more than enough reason for a suspicious Emperor to eliminate Prince Shangshan.

Clearing the line of succession.

Just as there couldn't be two suns in the sky, there couldn't be two Sons of Heaven.

The current Emperor ruled over the court and the people by suppressing their discontent, but he remained a tyrant and a traitor.

No, that legacy would pass to his new heir as surely as the blood in his veins.

Along with the label of a traitor's child.

The powerful men holding back their resentment toward the Emperor wouldn't welcome that. Those who'd drawn up the pledge—basically a rolling paper for signatures—already had an excellent alternative in Prince Shangshan.

And if Prince Shangshan disappeared, the Emperor couldn't ask for a better outcome.

The air in the pavilion was heavy and cold, as if everyone were thinking the same thing I was.

Hong Jin had been staring into space, his gaze sunk deep, and a long silence had passed before he suddenly spoke.

"How did you guess?"

"What do you mean?"

"I know a fair amount about the imperial palace, but Young Master Jin couldn't have made that guess just from knowing that a woman named Aehyang was staying in Qianqing Palace."

I thought back to what had happened.

"I couldn't have guessed from the sound alone. There was one other thing."

"What was it?"

"The smell."

"The smell?"

"Yes. It was faint, but I could clearly smell medicinal herbs. More precisely, a decoction."

"A decoction…"

"To be honest, I do have people around me who know a lot about that sort of thing, but I don't know exactly which herbs were used or what went into it. Still, when I thought about it, I could work out the general answer."

I went on slowly.

"People take decoctions when they're sick or need to build up their strength. So why would the Emperor be giving Aehyang one now? Was she simply ill, and he was worried about her? Or was there another reason?"

Fit all the circumstances and clues together, and a picture emerged.

This time was no different.

From what I'd seen, the Emperor was no lovesick romantic, and Qianqing Palace was no ordinary place.

"I could hardly believe it myself. That's why I came back as quickly as I could."

Hong Jin let out a low groan.

"How likely do you think it is, Young Master Jin?"

"Do you want the cold, hard answer?"

"Yes. The cold, hard answer."

"At least ninety percent."

"…!"

"I'm sorry. But everything fits together too perfectly, as far as I can tell."

It was a damnable reality, but I had to acknowledge it.

Why had the Emperor, after leaving Prince Shangshan alone for over a decade, suddenly summoned him to the imperial capital? Why had he all but forced him to stay in Qianqing Palace?

And… why might he want to harm him?

One answer resolved every question.

A new heir.

Hong Jin couldn't have missed it, either.

No, he was probably more certain than anyone.

Even Ma Sanbao, who'd visited the night before, hadn't said a word about something this important. The Emperor had kept Aehyang's condition secret even from the East Depot.

Hong Jin, who'd held a fairly high position within the East Depot, couldn't fail to understand what that meant.

Call it a guess, but read it as certainty.

The Emperor's seed was growing inside Aehyang. It was all but a foregone conclusion.

He just doesn't want to believe it.

I muttered to myself and watched Hong Jin in silence. Then I brought up one of the questions that still hadn't been answered.

"I know this isn't the best time, but may I ask you something?"

Hong Jin's voice was subdued. "Anything."

"Why didn't the Emperor eliminate Prince Shangshan sooner? I mean…"

“Why didn’t he kill him?”

I nodded silently, and Hong Jin continued.

“I can’t know exactly what was in the Emperor’s heart, but one thing is certain. He was probably afraid of the backlash if he killed even a young prince who hadn’t been weaned yet.”

“Hadn’t he already killed countless people?”

“The purge didn’t happen overnight. Especially not the purge of the imperial family.”

“Tell me more.”

“Right after the Fourth Prince’s rebellion succeeded, the late Emperor and the other members of the direct imperial family were confined under strict surveillance. Then, over the course of a year, they died one after another, as if they’d arranged it among themselves. Strange, isn’t it?”

His voice was calm, but he couldn’t hide the shock and fear that lingered beneath it.

With a trembling hand, Hong Jin drew a long-stemmed tobacco pipe from inside his robe and lit it.

Hoo.

He took a deep breath and exhaled a pale plume of smoke.

For a moment, I thought I’d smelled it somewhere before. Then I turned my attention back to his story.

“I mobilized the East Depot’s full strength to rescue the late Emperor and the other royals, but every attempt failed. Everything I did was already being watched. It wouldn’t have surprised me if they’d thrown me in prison the very next day.”

“But the Emperor didn’t kill you.”

“That’s right. Maybe it was our old ties, or maybe it was a whim. Either way, the Fourth Prince let me live.”

“Old ties?”

“I spent decades in the imperial palace. I served the late Emperor closely, so I crossed paths with the Fourth Prince often enough. He was a talented, sharp-minded boy in many ways. At least back then.”

Hong Jin watched the smoke drift toward the ceiling, his gaze empty.

“In any case, I survived. I was finally allowed to see the late Emperor shortly before he passed away. His mind was clouded, almost as if he’d gone mad, but he still entrusted Prince Shangshan to me.”

“Wait. Gone mad?”

“Yes. But why would that—oh.”

Hong Jin realized what I was getting at. Confusion crossed his face.

“Surely not?”

"It's possible. What exactly were his symptoms?"

"I saw him for less than fifteen minutes, so it's hard to say. He'd been healthy enough to father a child at his age, but he was old."

"I know. The rebellion and confinement must have been a terrible shock. But I need you to tell me exactly what you saw. That's the only way…"

"We can see whether it was like what happened to the City Lord of Sichuan Province?"

"…!"

Hyuk Mujin, who'd been listening with a dry swallow, widened his eyes. I nodded quietly.

Two words came to mind—*Dark Heaven*—along with the cursed creature I'd seen only about two weeks ago.

Blood Soul Gu.

A venomous creature that even Sichuan's most renowned physicians had failed to detect.

It left almost no trace as it drove its host to death. Created centuries ago by the Five Poisons Sect of Nanman, it had been found in the corpse of the City Lord of Sichuan Province.

And the City Lord of Sichuan Province started showing strange symptoms months ago, on his way back from the imperial capital.

Could it really be a coincidence?

Hong Jin's face had gone so rigid that I thought I could find the answer there.

"How likely do you think it is?"

After a silence, Hong Jin answered.

"Ten percent. No… twenty."

"Do you know how the other royals confined back then died?"

"It was never made public. They were simply forgotten."

"Then…"

"I'm going to contact Eunuch Ma tonight at the latest. His Highness's life… may be in immediate danger."

Right.

If the Emperor had planted Blood Soul Gu in the City Lord of Sichuan Province a few months ago and in the late Emperor more than a decade ago—or if Dark Heaven had done it with his help—Prince Shangshan was as good as dead.

But…

"I entrusted His Highness with a precious artifact I'd been carrying. We don't need to worry too much right away."

The Myriad-Poison Ring.

The Sichuan Tang Clan's divine artifact had detoxified the Formless Ultimate Poison that had brought down even Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, though he'd suffered a serious injury.

Blood Soul Gu was, in the end, a venomous creature created by the Five Poisons Sect. It couldn't be beyond the Myriad-Poison Ring's power.

No. It *had* to work.

"And one more thing. There's something I'd like to ask Eunuch Ma to do for me personally."

Hong Jin's eyes widened at what I said next.

Hangzhou, in Zhejiang Province, had been one of the finest cities in the world for pleasure-seekers even before the imperial court moved there.

It had countless historic sights and beautiful views. Vast quantities of goods and wealth moved along its canals, and its brightly lit streets bustled with people late into the night.

A city that never slept, in every sense.

So there was nothing unusual about a customer arriving late at one of the many shops lining the imperial capital's main road.

The employee's attitude toward him was a little unusual, though.

"Go on, take a look around. If you like anything, ask me then."

The middle-aged employee looked bored to death, his manner dripping with brusqueness. The customer studied him for a moment, then parted his lips.

"I've brought a message from the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon."

"…!"

Beneath a sign that read *Hyuk Family Textile Shop*, the middle-aged employee—no, Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King—opened his eyes wide.

Chapter 878

The moment he heard the Sound Transmission, Jeok Cheongang moved with remarkable speed—and made it look perfectly natural.

“Oh, you’re looking for the finest Shu brocade[3343]? You should’ve said so earlier. Come on in.”

“No, wait. I was only…”

The man disguised as a customer tried to protest, but the terrifying qi flowing through Jeok Cheongang’s grip on his wrist left him gaping.

“Gah.”

The pressure felt as though it would crush his entire body.

He instinctively summoned his internal energy to protect his wrist. It did no good.

No—when he saw the flames pouring from Jeok Cheongang’s eyes, even the last scrap of his will crumbled to ash.

What the hell is with that look…

This wasn’t a man. He was a born beast of prey. A predator.

Frozen stiff against his will, the man was dragged deep into the textile shop.

Between towering stacks of cotton cloth and silk, two figures emerged like ghosts from a shadowy corner.

Thud.

In the faint lamplight, the faces of two young men, both around thirty, came into view.

One wore an expression as dry as if he’d been chewing sand. The other was handsome, but his sharply upturned eyes made him look almost sly.

Neither had the sort of face that made dealing with people easy.

The especially grim-looking young man spoke first, in a painfully awkward tone.

“Hey, Mr. Jeok. What’s going on?”

Jeok Cheongang answered, “Hey, Mr. Jeok? Are you that eager to shit blood?”

“…Oh. Not right now?”

“Can’t you tell by looking? How did you survive as a wandering martial artist with that little sense?”

“I’m sorry.”

The grim-looking young man bowed his head. Song Ilseom spoke again, more carefully this time.

“May I ask who that man is?”

“A customer.”

[3343] Shu is a historical name for Sichuan. Shu brocade is a silk textile traditionally woven there.

Jeok Cheongang gave the brief reply, then added, “But he used Sound Transmission. Mentioned a sobriquet that starts with ‘Blazing’ and ends with ‘Dragon.‘”

Song Ilseom replied at once. “I’ll close up for today.”

“Make sure the shop is secured. Oh, first, circle the area. If you see anyone suspicious, grab the bastard and bring him here too.”

“Yes. But if I have no choice…?”

“What the hell are you asking me for? In that situation, slit his throat first.”

“Understood.”

“Just clean up after yourself. Make sure no one notices.”

“Leave it to me.”

Song Ilseom bowed politely and left at once. The man who’d heard their conversation felt his knees go weak.

Is this a textile shop or a slaughterhouse?

Could they be… an assassin organization?

Nothing in his orders had mentioned anything like this.

As his mouth went dry, the other young man spoke up.

“What should I do?”

“Bring the rest here. Every last one of them.”

“It’ll be difficult to bring everyone right away. One of them is out.”

“Damn it, what kind of goddamn idiot can’t sit still for a minute?”

“Well, it’s Young Lady Ju.”

“She’s allowed to go out for a while. Right. Of course. She must’ve gone to check on the situation nearby. How thoughtful of her.”

“…”

“Quit looking at me like that and go fetch the other freeloaders.”

“Yes.”

“Hey.”

“Yes?”

Jeok Cheongang stopped the young man as he was turning away and frowned.

“I told you not to look at me like that. Do my words sound like bullshit to you?”

“My eyes have looked this way since I was a child, so there’s nothing I can do about—no. I’m sorry. If I get the chance someday, I’ll be reborn.”

“Good. That way you can reincarnate. Maybe you’ll have kinder-looking eyes next time.”

“Yes…”

Sama Pyo, the young man cursed with sorrowfully upturned eyes, left with a feeble reply. Jeok Cheongang suddenly reached toward something.

Swish.

Qi stretched out, invisible, and the air around them trembled.

So did the man's pupils as he watched a wooden chest float through the air toward them.

Seizing an Object Through Empty Space!

The man belonged to a rather extraordinary organization himself, so this wasn't the first time he'd seen the technique. But he knew even a skilled internal-energy master would have to concentrate to pull in a chest that heavy.

Yet the middle-aged man before him had done it with ease.

With one casual wave of his hand.

Could it be…?

A possibility occurred to him, and he spoke cautiously.

"Could your sobriquet be the Fire King?"

Instead of answering, Jeok Cheongang blinked at him as if he were some curious creature. Then he kicked the man in the shin as fast as a flash.

Crack!

"Gah!"

"You little shit! You're still wet behind the ears, and half your tongue seems to be missing. What was that—'you'?"

"W-wait! Wait! Hear me out! I…"

"Stay right where you are. Move and you'll get hurt worse."

Thwack! Thwack! Thwack!

The grappling technique he'd practiced until his arms were bruised and the footwork technique he'd drilled until his leg muscles screamed were useless now.

After blows to the shin, stomach, chest, and finally the bridge of his nose, the man collapsed like a kite with its string cut.

Thump.

Of course, he wasn't even allowed to pass out.

"Up."

He sprang to his feet far faster than he'd fallen. His voice trembled as he spoke.

"Are you Great Hero Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King?"

His tone could not have been more respectful.

Jeok Cheongang had perched on the chest he'd drawn over with Seizing an Object Through Empty Space. He looked as satisfied as a surgeon who'd just completed a difficult operation.

"Your severed tongue has finally grown back in the right place. Yes, this old man is Jeok Cheongang. And who are you?"

"This humble servant…"

“I don’t need to know a nobody like you’s name. Just tell me who you work for. I can tell at a glance you’re an eunuch, anyway.”

“…!”

“What? Was that such a big secret?”

The man—or rather, the eunuch—was momentarily speechless. Jeok Cheongang gave a short laugh and continued.

“I’ll admit, you’ve put together a convincing disguise. That human-skin mask, even the beard—they look like they’re yours. But that’s not enough to fool this old man.”

“Then how did you…?”

“I felt your pulse earlier. You didn’t have nearly enough yang qi for a man. Now, tell me—which is more likely in the imperial palace courtyard: running into a eunuch, or running into a martial artist without balls? I don’t need to spell it out, do I?”

The eunuch swallowed hard. Jeok Cheongang’s judgment was sharp, but what unsettled him more was that knowing he was a eunuch hadn’t changed the man’s attitude at all.

“Then you must know where I came from, too.”

“Of course. The only place in the world with the perverse hobby of ripping the balls off perfectly healthy men is the imperial palace.”

“…”

“Stop rambling and answer what I asked. Exactly where in the imperial palace do you serve? Are you under that eunuch who’s Prince Shangshan’s right hand? The East Depot? Or are you one of the ones licking the Emperor’s…”

“The East Depot.”

“The East Depot, eh? The place where they gather the most stubborn and vicious eunuchs under heaven. So why has one of you come all the way here?”

“The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—no, your Disciple asked me to pass on several messages.”

“And the Emperor isn’t laying a trap?”

“Absolutely not. Your Disciple was the one who told us you were staying here.”

“That sounds plausible. But with the East Depot’s intelligence network, it wouldn’t be strange if you’d found out some other way. How will you prove it?”

As Jeok Cheongang’s eyes narrowed, the eunuch hurried to answer.

“M-Mong-su-ta.”

“What?”

“Your Disciple told me to say it. I have no idea what it means, but he said if I passed it on, I’d at least avoid shitting blood…”

The eunuch waited in dread. Fortunately, Jeok Cheongang knew exactly what the clumsily pronounced word meant.

Monster.

The monsters from the other world that had stained the realm of immortals with blood.

And only two people under heaven knew about them: Jin Taekyung and himself.

“Hmm. He definitely sent you.”

“Y-yes.”

“If you’d said that sooner, I wouldn’t have had to hit you. Forgive this old man’s rudeness, my good castrate.”

The eunuch wanted to say that calling a eunuch a castrate was about as rude as it got, but he held his tongue.

If he ran his mouth again, he might really end up shitting blood.

His best course was to leave as quickly as possible.

Swish.

He reached deep into his robes, took out a small tube, and handed it over. Jeok Cheongang’s eyes grew serious.

“Is this the missive Jin Taekyung told you to deliver?”

“Yes.”

“And the other one?”

As Jeok Cheongang had said, there were two tightly sealed tubes. The eunuch spoke in a low voice.

“The person I serve ordered me to deliver this one.”

“The person you serve?”

“You seem to know the Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province.”

“Hong Jin? I’ve never met him, but I heard about him on the way here. A fairly decent eunuch, apparently.”

“…Yes. The person I serve is close to him. He said the contents would help with what you’re going to do.”

“Is that all? Nothing else to tell me?”

“That’s all. I’m only a messenger.”

That was the extent of the eunuch’s orders.

He hurried out of the vast slaughterhouse—or rather, the textile shop—using a footwork technique. Left alone, Jeok Cheongang broke the seals and drew out two rolled-up missives.

Rustle.

The smell of oil-treated paper mingled with the stale air inside the shop.

Jin Taekyung’s missive opened with the immortal line *“Looks like we’re screwed.”* Jeok Cheongang read it, then quickly went through the information prepared with the East Depot’s help. He let out a quiet sigh.

“What a goddamn mess.”

And then—

Fwoosh.

Flames from Samadhi[3344] True Fire swallowed both missives, writhing in the darkness.

As Jeok Cheongang silently watched the missives turn to ash and vanish with a soft rustle in the blink of an eye—

“I brought everyone.”

Sama Pyo, who’d left only moments ago, approached with some familiar faces, then stopped short.

“Where is that man?”

“I sent him away a little while ago. Fortunately, he wasn’t suspicious.”

“Did you find out who he was?”

“An eunuch. One Jin Taekyung sent.”

“…What?”

Jeok Cheongang ignored Sama Pyo’s confusion at that painfully brief explanation.

“Where the hell were those people? What took you so long to bring them?”

Yaaawn.

Sama Pyo nudged Taishan in the side as he yawned, his eyes still sleepy, then hesitated.

“Well, you see…”

“Holed up in a corner sleeping, were they?”

“I think they dozed off for a bit.”

“Tell him next time he’ll sleep forever.”

“Yes.”

“What about Namho?”

Sama Pyo glanced at the old man, Namho, who was panting in rumpled clothes, and answered.

“He was choking Taishan.”

“Why?”

“Taishan drank all the liquor Elder Namho had hidden away.”

For a brief, tempting moment, Jeok Cheongang imagined choking Taishan and Namho at the same time. Then he sighed deeply.

“Quit screwing around and get ready, all of you.”

“Pardon me, but what should we…”

“We’re going to the imperial palace soon.”

“What? How?”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyes gleamed as he answered.

[3344] Samadhi is a Sanskrit term for a state of deep meditative absorption.

“Don’t worry. We’ve been formally invited.”

Chapter 879

Where there are people, there are rumors.

Hangzhou, Zhejiang Province—the heart of the world and the new imperial capital of the Great Nation—was no exception.

If anything, it was one of the worst places for them.

Wherever you went in Hangzhou, you found people repeating rumors they'd heard from someone else as if they were facts, spittle flying as they talked.

They discussed the beauty of a high official's new concubine—the sort of official said to be powerful enough to knock a bird from the sky. They grew furious over the story that he'd squeezed the people dry to buy her expensive jewelry. And when they heard the Embroidered Uniform Guard had begun investigating, they raised their cups again and again.

"Times like this, there's no one more dependable than the Embroidered Uniform Guard. He may have committed crimes against his own family to take the throne, but at least he knows how to get things done…"

"Shh. Shut that reckless mouth of yours. Didn't you say one of that old official's sons was in the Embroidered Uniform Guard?"

"I did."

"And he still got caught? Even with connections in the Guard?"

"Oh, that one. Apparently, he was dismissed not long ago."

"Really? Why?"

"Don't know. Maybe he was on some secret assignment. He disappeared about a month ago, then came back a few days ago with his face all swollen."

"Swollen?"

"Yeah. Looks like he got a real beating for something he did wrong."

The story drifted away as quickly as it had come.

Poets and scholars seeking inspiration among scenic landmarks. Idlers who'd traveled a thousand *li*[3345] to visit Hangzhou, the city of pleasure.

Poor scholars quietly sipping cheap strong liquor over a plate of dumplings, and wealthy merchants patting their bulging bellies.

Hangzhou was full of all kinds of people, and they talked freely about what they'd seen and heard.

"I've finally seen West Lake. I could die right now without a single regret. If I had my way, I'd stay in Hangzhou for another year."

"You've still got more than a month before you have to go home. What's the rush? Let's take our time looking around, then visit the Zhoushan Archipelago before we leave."

[3345]The Chinese *li* is a unit of distance equal to 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand *li* is about 500 km (311 mi).

“The Zhoushan Archipelago? Are you thinking of going to Mount Putuo?”

“That’s right. I don’t believe in Buddha, but if a famous mountain like that is nearby, I might as well visit while I’m here.”

“But I heard the nuns there are practically martial artists…”

“If you mean the Buddhist nuns at Putuo Temple, there’s no need to worry. They disappeared more than ten years ago, when the imperial capital moved here and Hangzhou’s martial artists were driven out.”

The poets and scholars who’d come to see Hangzhou’s famous sights were in fairly high spirits. The merchants seated nearby, on the other hand, kept pouring down liquor with sour expressions.

“Things are looking bad in Sichuan these days. Prices are swinging so wildly they’re impossible to predict. I’ve taken quite a hit.”

“Then is that rumor true? That foreign forces are about to pour in from Qinghai? They say even the Kunlun Sect, based in Qinghai, is on the brink.”

“Foreign forces? They’re nothing but lawless thugs from the martial world—fanatics thoroughly bewitched by demons, at that. They’ve given themselves a fancy new name, but they’ll still get smashed by the Central Plains sects, just like the Demonic Cult did in the past. The Imperial Guards won’t even need to get involved this time.”

“You’ve been in Hangzhou too long these past few years. You don’t know the first thing about what’s happening in the world.”

“Oh? Have you heard something?”

“A martial artist I’ve known for a long time is with the Murim Alliance now… He says this is far worse than when the Demonic Cult invaded.”

“What? That bad?”

“Just look at what happened in Sichuan a few months ago. Nearly ten thousand troops gathered and fought a bloody battle. At that scale, you can hardly call it an internal dispute within the martial world. It’s practically a war between small nations.”

“…!”

“And that’s not all. Nothing’s been confirmed yet, but there are signs of some kind of movement in Yunnan, too.”

“Yunnan? You don’t mean those Nanman barbarians?”

“That’s right. They say the Nanman Beast Palace is mobilizing all its forces and marching north into the Central Plains. If the rumor’s true, they may have already reached Sichuan or Guangxi.”

“Hah. The fanatics weren’t enough, and now the barbarians are eyeing the Central Plains too?”

“No, it’s the complete opposite. They’re joining the Murim Alliance to fight Dark Heaven. But something about it is strange.”

“If that’s true, shouldn’t we be glad? What’s strange about it?”

“Well… I heard those barbarians are fanatics too.”

“What?”

“Apparently they spend all day spouting weird nonsense about how fighting Dark Heaven is a holy war, and how the Earth Mother Goddess watches over them.”

“What kind of fucking nonsense is that?”

“How should I know? I only heard it through my connections, several people down the line. Anyway, it’s clear something much bigger is happening than anyone thinks.”

The continent was vast. But merchants, whose line of work forced them to keep their ears open, heard all kinds of information through all kinds of channels.

Whether a rumor was true or not, it was worth remembering. Someday, it might make them a fortune.

Just as the inn had grown noisy with conversation and clinking cups, someone tossed out a slurred remark.

“Oh, have you heard? They say His Highness, Prince Shangshan, is staying in the imperial palace.”

“…!”

“…!”

In an instant, the air that had been warm with drink went cold.

Silence fell over the inn. Every gaze turned toward the same place.

“Huh?”

Startled by all the eyes suddenly fixed on him, the thoroughly drunk middle-aged man stammered.

“W-Why is everyone looking at me?”

Then a few people in the now-quiet inn spoke up.

“What did you just say?”

“His Highness, Prince Shangshan, is staying in the imperial palace? Not in Shanxi Province, his fief?”

“Are you sure about what you just said?”

Disaster always came from liquor and loose tongues.

As the questions came flying at him, the middle-aged man realized something was wrong. He sobered up all at once.

“I-I don’t know if it’s true. I only heard it somewhere. It’s probably just a rumor.”

“Even if it’s a rumor, tell us. Everything you know.”

“No, no. I must’ve said something foolish because I’m drunk. I need to leave now, so please let me through…”

His flushed face had long since turned pale.

Though he managed to stagger to his feet, he couldn’t take a single step. Something dropped from above and stopped him in his tracks.

Thud.

It landed right in front of his feet with a solid thump. The leather cord around its opening came loose, spilling the contents.

Clatter.

Silver nyang spilled from the money pouch, glinting in the dim light.

At a glance, there were more than thirty.

As people gaped at the enormous sum, a quiet voice reached their ears.

“That was quite an interesting story.”

Everyone turned again. No—looked up.

On the second floor, a young scholar sat alone at a table, watching the middle-aged man.

“Fifty silver nyang. I’d say that’s enough for the story. What do you think?”

“…!”

The middle-aged man’s eyelid twitched.

He was stunned by the sum of fifty silver nyang—and by the young scholar who’d tossed it down so casually.

Enough?

It was more than enough. Far more.

Fifty silver nyang.

As a day laborer on Hangzhou’s canals, he’d never even dreamed of touching so much money. Just looking at it made his heart pound.

But the possible consequences of the words he’d tossed out so carelessly weighed on him as heavily as that pouch.

“W-Who are you, sir? You look like you come from a good family. Did I say something I shouldn’t have…?”

“There’s no need to worry. I’m simply curious.”

Fifty silver nyang just to satisfy his curiosity?

That was ridiculous.

Even a rich young master wouldn’t throw away that kind of money for no reason.

The young scholar’s answer made the middle-aged man even more uneasy, but he couldn’t let a chance to change his life slip away.

Even this vast imperial capital, the center of the world, had its share of poor people. For one of them, fifty silver nyang meant a whole new life.

Clatter.

Having made up his mind, he hurriedly gathered the spilled silver and stuffed it back into the pouch before anyone could steal it. He swallowed, then spoke to the young scholar.

“Near dawn, I was hanging around a gambling den when I heard the story. They said several hundred members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard had entered through the North Gate a few days ago. Even for the imperial capital, the guards along the main road and the atmosphere were unusual that day.”

“Go on.”

“A few sharp-eyed fellows thought something was off, so they risked a scolding and snuck a look. Would you believe it? Those terrifying guards had surrounded a single carriage so tightly you could barely see it.”

“A carriage?”

“Yes. Not particularly grand, not especially small, either. The sort of thing you’d use to transport goods.”

“And His Highness, Prince Shangshan, was inside?”

“They said they saw him with their own eyes. A boy’s face appeared at the window—he looked extraordinary at a glance. They said he was definitely the Prince Shangshan everyone’s heard about…”

“That alone doesn’t seem like enough.”

“Pardon?”

The young scholar cut him off and continued.

“It’s been more than ten years since His Highness, Prince Shangshan, left the capital. He was very young even then, and even now he isn’t fifteen. How could someone who spends his nights hanging around a gambling den recognize His Highness’s face?”

“I-I suppose he guessed after seeing hundreds of guards make such a fuss.”

“Perhaps. But there must have been another reason for that guess. I’ve already paid you well. Tell me everything you saw and heard, without leaving anything out.”

The inn had been bustling with noise only moments ago. Now it was as quiet as a grave.

That was what Prince Shangshan meant to ordinary people.

Noble, yet pitiable.

An unfortunate member of the imperial family, exiled in all but name to far-off Shanxi Province after losing his entire family to an older brother who’d defied the bonds of kinship.

And now they said His Highness, Prince Shangshan, had returned to the capital.

After more than ten years—and secretly, surrounded by the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Under the weight of all those questioning looks, the middle-aged man hunched his shoulders and struggled to speak.

“At first, I thought the same thing as you, Young Master. How could it be true? How could the likes of him recognize His Highness, Prince Shangshan? Why would someone who’d spent more than ten years in the provinces suddenly come to the capital? That sort of thing. But…”

“But?”

“When I heard the rest, it sounded pretty convincing.”

The middle-aged man paused to catch his breath. Then, in a silence so deep not even breathing could be heard, he continued.

“That fellow jumped up and said, ‘The Emperor—no, His Majesty the Emperor—is expecting an heir. Of course his younger brother, His Highness Prince Shangshan, would come. He was surely invited to the celebration that’s about to be held.’”

“…!”

“…!”

For an instant, an invisible shockwave swept through the inn.

Sharp intakes of breath broke the silence, and the dim lamplight fell on people frozen in place.

The young scholar’s face had gone rigid, too.

“An… heir?”

“Yes. He didn’t know whether it was the Empress or one of the concubines, but he said she was definitely pregnant.”

The young scholar’s gaze darkened.

Some of the more than a hundred customers in the inn reacted the same way.

The ones biting their lips to hide their shock were poets, scholars, and merchants. Unlike the middle-aged man and a few other simpletons, they understood exactly what those words might mean.

If all of that is true…

The thought alone frightened them.

A new heir for an Emperor who’d long had none. And the return of Prince Shangshan, the only direct member of the imperial family to survive the bloodshed more than a decade ago.

What could that possibly mean?

A purge…!

A silent scream rang in their heads. Their backs were already slick with cold sweat as they sensed the danger.

They should have left long ago.

Whether the rumor was true or not, this was a story they should never have heard.

At that moment, they felt as if they were standing at the edge of a thousand-

zhang[3346] cliff, one misstep from a fall they could never climb back from.

The middle-aged man, meanwhile, was happily counting his silver. He and a few others hadn't grasped the danger at all.

"So His Majesty is finally expecting an heir. What a blessing for the whole country."

"What blessing? The child will inherit the blood of a man who broke the bonds of kinship to take the throne—"

"Please, just shut your mouth. Do you have three or four lives to spare? Do you want to get me killed too? If someone reports us, we're all finished."

"If you're so afraid of people overhearing, go hide at home. People have always cursed the ruler where he can't hear them. The Embroidered Uniform Guard aren't ghosts. What are the chances we'll run into them? Honestly."

"But what will happen to His Highness, Prince Shangshan?"

"What would a nobody like me know? I just hope he stays in the capital from now on. He suffered such terrible things as a child. Who knows what that's done to him? It's about time he could live somewhere in peace."

Stories always grew in the telling, and people believed what they wanted to believe.

The incredible rumor the middle-aged man had passed on had already become, in the minds of the crowd, a fact backed by solid evidence. A few of those who'd sensed the danger from the start forced their trembling legs to carry them across the noisy inn.

Some meant to escape before they were caught in a fire they couldn't survive.

Others meant to confirm the information and use it.

But when they reached the entrance, they realized they'd stepped into a mire they could no longer escape.

"Where are you all hurrying off to?"

At the low voice, a dozen or so shadows blocking the old doorway stepped forward together.

Step.

For a moment, it was as if the world had stopped.

Those hurrying to leave saw ten men with bamboo hats pulled low—and golden armor flashing beneath their wind-cloaks.

"The Embroidered Uniform Guard…!"

The words escaped someone's lips like a scream, and the inn froze.

Then the young scholar, who'd been sitting silently in thought, spoke.

"That was a truly interesting story. Well worth fifty silver nyang."

The middle-aged man, clutching the pouch full of silver, stared blankly.

[3346] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft); a thousand *zhang* is about 3.03 km (1.88 mi).

“Young Master, what on earth is going on…?”

“I’m no young master. But I still want to hear more of your story.”

“Y-Young Master! You can’t do this! You can’t…!”

The young scholar paid no attention to his shouts.

The young scholar—no, the hundred-household officer of the Embroidered Uniform Guard—addressed his subordinates at the entrance in a mild voice.

“What are you waiting for? Arrest every one of them.”

“Loyalty!”

With a sharp salute, ten golden figures raced in every direction.

Every one of them was a master whose martial arts had reached Supreme First Rate or Peak.

Shouts and tearful pleas burst out across the inn. An instant later, the screams of those trying to flee or fight back drowned them out.

Bang! Crash!

Amid the crashes ringing through the inn, the Embroidered Uniform Guard captain leaped from the second-floor railing and landed lightly on the ground. He patted the trembling middle-aged man on the shoulder.

“Now, it’s noisy here. Let’s go somewhere else and talk. You can tell me what else you know, who fed you that bullshit, and who else has heard it.”

He didn’t bother to tell the man what would pay for his story this time.

It wouldn’t be silver. But it would shine just as brightly—and be far sharper.

After hearing the report, the Emperor remained silent for a long time, even after the messenger withdrew. Only when one other person remained did he finally speak.

“What do you think?”

From between the dense strings of pearls and the silks drifting around them, someone answered.

“Someone must have spread the rumor deliberately.”

“Who?”

“Isn’t it obvious? The East Depot, Jin Taekyung—the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—or… both.”

“They’ve joined forces?”

“That’s the only possibility for now.”

“I’m beginning to regret it. Perhaps I shouldn’t have listened to you and let Jin Taekyung into the imperial palace.”

The Emperor clicked his tongue and murmured, almost to himself.

“Did the person who sent you to me foresee this, too?”

Someone beyond the silks answered.

“That person is greater and wiser than anyone I know. But Jin Taekyung is unpredictable. He cannot be easily judged.”

Without realizing it, the Emperor nodded.

Jin Taekyung’s audacity was impossible to fathom. So were his martial prowess and his convictions.

Whatever their respective positions, the Jin Taekyung he’d seen the day before had been enough to make even the Emperor let out an incredulous laugh.

“We’d better rein him in before he jeopardizes the great undertaking. And what of the target?”

“It won’t be easy. Not at present.”

“Of course. If it were easy, he wouldn’t have been a thorn in our side for more than ten years. But the Great Nation cannot be set right until he’s gone. You must see it done.”

Rustle.

In place of an answer, a faint breeze stirred the silks.

The Emperor realized that the person who’d been there only moments ago had vanished. He gave a bitter smile and muttered,

“The rumor’s already out. There’s no point trying to hide it now. We’ll have to make it true.”

It was the moment that heralded a grand celebration of the birth of a new heir to inherit the Great Nation.

Chapter 880

A fire rising from a dense bed of reeds was not easily stopped, even by fierce wind and rain.

Neither were the rumors that had suddenly begun sweeping through the Imperial Capital.

“Have you heard? His Highness, Prince Shangshan, is in the imperial palace right now…”

“They say the Emperor finally has an heir.”

“I heard they’ll hold a great banquet soon. That must be why His Highness, Prince Shangshan, returned after more than ten years.”

“But an heir? Does that mean Her Majesty the Empress is pregnant?”

“Who knows for sure? Jang next door told me it’s a new concubine the Emperor recently took…”

“Jang next door? The butcher?”

“That’s the one. You know him too?”

“Of course. That man knows how to slaughter livestock. But where on earth did he hear it?”

“From someone… what was his name? Oh, right. Wu, who runs the shop across the street.”

“Then who did Wu hear it from?”

“Li the woodcutter.”

Even the Embroidered Uniform Guard, said to be capable of catching a bird in flight and dragging it off to prison, could scarcely silence so many mouths.

The rumors spread so quickly that the imperial palace’s towering walls might as well not have been there. In a single night, the Embroidered Uniform Guard dragged away hundreds of people.

“If you want to live, tell us everything. Which bastard has been spreading this nonsense?”

“Eek! I’ll tell you! I’ll tell you everything!”

Everyone knew what happened when the Embroidered Uniform Guard took someone away. You were as good as dead. Even the highest officials could be cut down like weeds.

The prisoners knew that reputation well. Before the guards even brought out the instruments of torture, they told them everything they knew. Yet for all the ease of the interrogations, the Guard learned nothing useful.

“What did they say?”

“All of them say the same thing. They heard it from ordinary neighbors with no ties to the imperial palace, street vendors, or strangers they met at inns and pleasure houses.”

“Damn it.”

Countless names had come up during the interrogations, but every lead was an empty shell. The people the prisoners named were utterly ordinary, and the source of the rumors spreading across the capital remained a mystery.

It was like being ordered to find a vein of gold in an exhausted mine.

But they were the Embroidered Uniform Guard. In this vast realm, they owed absolute loyalty to one person alone: the Emperor. Whatever the circumstances, they had to produce results.

“Begin the interrogation in earnest.”

“Pardon?”

“Use whatever methods you need. Find the culprits as quickly as possible.”

“B-but those people…”

“They’ve thrown the Great Nation into turmoil with baseless rumors and sullied His Majesty’s name. Are they subjects of this country, or traitors?”

The officers fell silent at their superior’s command. They knew the prisoners trembling in their cells were nothing more than ignorant commoners.

Just as no storeroom was so clean that shaking it wouldn’t stir up dust, countless high officials had passed through the Guard’s prison, each with a crime or two to their name, great or small.

But these people were ordinary subjects. When the wind blew, they bent; when it rained, they got wet.

And now the officers were to torture them. They had to send their superiors results, even if it meant killing those people horribly or leaving them half-crippled.

The officers took pride in punishing corrupt and disloyal people in power to set the Great Nation in order. This left them uneasy.

But…

“Answer me!”

At their superior’s renewed roar, they realized they had nowhere left to retreat. Military discipline was strict, especially in an institution as powerful as the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

“We obey the Thousand Captain’s orders.”

They answered reluctantly and were about to return to the cells when a quiet voice stopped them.

“Everyone, halt.”

A middle-aged man appeared and swept his gaze over them. His golden armor was spotless, his bearing imposing. The Thousand Captain recognized him at once, his eyes widening.

“Thousand Captain Jeong?”

Jeong Hogun gave a curt nod.

“It’s been a while, Thousand Captain Hong. How are the interrogations of last night’s prisoners going?”

“We’ll have proper results soon. But what do you mean, halt?”

“Just what I said. Stop. There’s nothing more to uncover.”

The Thousand Captain, who had been roaring at his subordinates moments ago, frowned at Jeong Hogun’s firm reply.

“You’re interfering more than usual today. Are you planning to overstep your authority?”

“Of course not.”

“Then what is this? No matter how much the Guard Commander favors you, this is clearly—”

“An imperial order.”

“What?”

“I said it’s an imperial order. The moment you receive it, you are to stop interrogating or torturing the prisoners brought in last night and release every one of them within half an hour. His Majesty commands it.”

“…!”

“What are you all waiting for? Obey the imperial order.”

Jeong Hogun’s sudden arrival settled the matter in an instant.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard officers knelt and formally received the imperial command, then streamed away like the tide to release the hundreds of prisoners. Their superior, the Thousand Captain, asked Jeong Hogun with a stony expression,

“What’s going on? And what about our report?”

“Forget the whole matter. That is His Majesty’s will.”

Jeong Hogun’s voice was as flat and unreadable as ever.

“I’ll get straight to the point. The rumors are true.”

“What?”

“I said they’re all true. The imperial court will make an official announcement soon. The Embroidered Uniform Guard will be responsible for the task.”

“…!”

“His Majesty has a good idea where the rumors came from, but he says there’s no point trying to establish the exact facts. Whoever planned and spread them so thoroughly will have left almost no evidence.”

“T-then…”

"A banquet will soon be held at the imperial palace to celebrate. His Highness, Prince Shangshan, will attend, as will every civil and military official. Until you receive further orders, see to security inside and outside the palace."

The matter of the Emperor's heir had been a closely guarded secret known to only a handful of people. The Thousand Captain had known of Prince Shangshan's return, but nothing of this. His face hardened like stone.

"You mean to confirm all of it—and announce it to the people? Now?"

"Exactly."

"Do you understand what that means, Thousand Captain Jeong? Or are you pretending you don't?"

"I understand well enough. Including something else you're overlooking."

"Something I'm overlooking? What are you—"

"What a mere military officer like me can guess, surely His Majesty the Emperor knows."

"…!"

"Follow the order."

Jeong Hogun left the speechless Thousand Captain behind. As he passed the dark cells and the people emerging from them one by one, he thought:

This is where it begins.

He could feel it: a great storm that would soon sweep through this splendid city called the Imperial Capital—no, through the whole realm.

The imperial court's formal announcement would be the first arrow, signaling everything to come.

Many people will gather. Many words will be exchanged.

The people drawn into this now would not be ordinary folk like those filling the cells. The so-called educated classes would take notice. Those with power, who could grasp what was happening and act on it, would begin to move.

And in the process…

At last, we'll know friend from foe.

Until war began, there was no telling who was an enemy and who was an ally. But when everyone drew their weapons and the fighting began in earnest, with no retreat possible, the truth would finally show itself.

Whatever form it took.

What choice will that bastard make in this war?

Jeong Hogun thought of a young man he could never quite figure out.

A reckless young ruffian of the martial world who had thrown himself into the eye of the storm.

"As daring as ever. Just like a little over ten years ago."

Hong Jin broke a long silence with those words, and I nodded quietly. I felt the same way.

This is more than I expected.

As soon as Ma Sanbao received the information I'd given him after my visit to Qianqing Palace, he acted. He sent trusted subordinates across the Imperial Capital to spread rumors about Prince Shangshan's whereabouts and everything concerning the Emperor's heir—which we still hadn't confirmed for certain.

But what the Emperor did next caught me completely off guard.

I can't believe he admitted it right away.

Even celebrities caught red-handed by Daspatch usually spend a day or two keeping quiet and denying the dating rumors. The Emperor had gone beyond admitting the rumors and announced them outright.

All in less than a day.

He sure is quick to act, but what on earth is he up to?

The more widely this became known, the worse it was for the Emperor. Unless the thing on his shoulders was purely decorative, anyone with a drop of ink on their hands and a working brain would come to roughly the same conclusion.

—Huh? The Emperor secretly brought Prince Shangshan into the palace?

—Huh? There's an Emperor Junior, and he hid that until he got caught?

—Huh? Now I'm pissed.

Those thoughts led to one conclusion:

—The Emperor might get rid of Prince Shangshan!

It would be one thing if he had a good reputation to begin with. But wasn't the current Son of Heaven the one who'd come to the throne after unleashing a river of blood?

A first-time offender might get probation for a minor crime. Nobody was going to trust a murderer with a record.

They might pretend not to notice because they're afraid of him, though.

In Go terms,[3347] the Emperor had made a terrible move. For us, though, it meant we could breathe a little easier. We'd tried to buy time so he couldn't recklessly threaten Prince Shangshan, and now that protection seemed firmer.

"Isn't this a decent situation? Whatever else, the imperial court has acknowledged everything in its own name. For now, the threats surrounding His Highness, Prince Shangshan, will disappear."

Hyuk Mujin had spoken cautiously, watching for their reactions. Hong Jin nodded.

"You're not wrong. But we always have to consider the worst."

"The worst…?"

[3347] Go is an East Asian strategy board game in which players compete to control territory.

“Young Master Jin, you can probably guess. You’ve experienced for yourself what the current Emperor is like.”

At their gaze, I smacked my lips and slowly began.

“Personally, I see two possibilities. One good, one bad. Which do you want first?”

“Hmm. I think I’d rather hear the bad one first.”

“Mujin.”

“Yes?”

“Read the room.”

“Yes.”

Hong Jin looked sympathetically at Hyuk Mujin, who had quietly shut his mouth, then spoke.

“The good one first.”

The good possibility.

I sorted through my thoughts once more, then slowly parted my lips.

“First: now that he’s made it public, the Emperor will find it hard to lay a hand on his only younger brother, and he’ll send him back safely after the banquet.”

“I like that one, but… what’s the bad one?”

“Second, now that things have come to this, he decides he can take being cursed out one more time and kills off every remaining dissident.”

Hong Jin fell silent. After a long while, he murmured, his expression dark.

“This banquet… could become a Hongmen Banquet.[3348]”

[3348] At the historical Feast at Hong Gate, a banquet became the setting for an attempt on Liu Bang’s life.

Chapter 881

They say rats hear what you say at night, and birds hear what you say by day.

But the guests who had gathered in a secret room early that morning at someone's invitation weren't the least bit troubled by such an old, tired saying.

Rats could be trampled to death. Birds could be shot down.

The only ones they worried about were the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Little more than the Emperor's watchdogs, the Guard wore golden armor as yellow as a mongrel's coat. Their specialty was combing every corner as if hunting for lice.

They sniffed out a target, tracked it down, sank their foul-smelling teeth into its neck, then ran back to their master, wagging their tails.

With so many eyes and ears throughout the Imperial Capital, though, even moving in the strictest secrecy left them uneasy, like a fish bone caught in the throat.

Perhaps that was why.

Though a dozen or so people had gathered in one place, an uncomfortable silence lingered in the secret room for some time.

Then, with a faint noise, the last person they were waiting for appeared.

Creeeak.

The old hatch overhead opened, and dim light spilled in. Their eyes, accustomed to the darkness, narrowed reflexively, but they didn't let down their guard.

They weren't sure the unfamiliar man who had just stepped into the room was the ally they knew so well.

The newcomer immediately understood what their looks meant.

"Ah, my apologies. I was in such a hurry to get here that I forgot for a moment."

Krrk. Crack.

"Hmm."

A low groan rose from them all at once. The dozen or so guests watched the changes around the man with grave expressions.

Shhhk.

His features rippled like a wave.

His long philtrum shortened, his unusually prominent bulbous nose grew sharp, and an odd light appeared in his once-dull, unfocused eyes.

That alone was astonishing enough, but the changes didn't stop there.

Crack.

With the sound of hundreds of bones shifting out of place, his body shrank and stretched, again and again.

The transformation happened in an instant. A moment later, not a trace of the man they'd just seen remained.

In his place stood a handsome, lean man in his thirties or forties.

At last, the guests recognized the face before them and relaxed.

"Your skill is as wondrous as ever."

"We ought to be used to it by now, but we still tense up every time. Brush-Holding Eunuch Ma, your talent truly is remarkable."

At the admiring remarks from all around, Ma Sanbao, the East Depot's Brush-Holding Eunuch, smiled faintly.

"It's just a parlor trick I happened to pick up."

Having modestly brushed off his astonishing disguise technique and Bone-Shrinking Technique, Ma Sanbao continued.

"More importantly, it seems everyone arrived at the appointed time. I hope the journey here wasn't too inconvenient."

The guests answered in more relaxed voices.

"It wasn't as bad as I expected. Your loyal subordinates helped us, and we took far greater care with our disguises."

"Of course, this ghastly thing is unpleasant and stifling, but what wouldn't we endure to evade those Embroidered Uniform Guard bastards?"

Someone pointed to the human-skin mask stretched over his face. The others nodded in agreement.

That was right.

What mattered wasn't whether this skin belonged to a person or an animal.

Their only goal was to overthrow the man sitting on the throne now—the Emperor who had brutally slaughtered countless longtime friends and comrades who shared their cause, then turned that fearsome blade on them.

"We can't let ourselves be crushed so easily again. Not if I want to save my family and my people."

"What can we do? There's no taking back water once it's spilled. We were all at fault for underestimating the Emperor—or rather, the Fourth Prince."

"Indeed. But that doesn't mean we have to scoop up water that's already dirty."

"Couldn't agree more. We can refill the vessel as it empties, and replace the cracked one that reeks of blood with a new one."

For a while, they spoke in measured voices.

They had ridden the tiger and were now clinging to its back. Only two choices remained: let fear drive them to climb down and be eaten alive, or hold on with all their might until the tiger exhausted itself—and plunge a dagger into the back of its neck.

Everyone gathered here had chosen the latter.

For survival, in the narrowest sense. And for a great and glorious future, in the broadest.

Thus, their fervent hopes and wishes came together, and at last they drew up a pledge bearing all their signatures.

They would wait for the time to defy heaven.

Fortunately, they didn't have long to wait.

More than a decade had passed since the day the Imperial Capital ran red with blood.

White frost had settled on the heads of the old ministers who had barely survived, but the faction they'd secretly built with painstaking effort had grown stronger and larger. The child who had left for the frontier bundled in swaddling clothes had returned as a boy. And an ominous air was slowly gathering over the Imperial Capital.

"Now everyone is watching the Emperor. The civil and military officials, and even the ignorant common folk."

"We only meant to buy ourselves a little time by spreading the rumors, but instead of denying them, he announced them to the whole world."

"For once, that cunning Emperor has made a blunder. Now that he's made the announcement, the flames will grow beyond anyone's control."

"Scandalous stories about the Emperor keep surfacing everywhere. It's hard to guess what he's planning."

"Ten years can change even mountains and rivers, but people don't change easily. Just look at me. I was already past seventy back then, and I'm still going strong."

"What do you mean…?"

"The Emperor is the same. This is one of his schemes. Perhaps he means to unleash another storm of blood."

At the aged voice of a man whose finely made human-skin mask made him look middle-aged, the others let out low groans.

Was it because they hadn't expected it at all?

No. His words had laid bare the truth they were all trying to ignore.

They too had stumbled and rolled through the filth of politics and lived to tell the tale.

They knew firsthand just how ruthless and daring the Emperor was.

Still, it was hard to shake the question: would he really go that far?

"Isn't that an overstatement? If the Emperor really intends to do that, rebellions might break out throughout the realm. No—they certainly will."

At that, the old minister disguised as a middle-aged man burst into a hearty laugh.

"Your own home, with all its furnishings and storehouses, is about to go up in

flames. Why worry about a fire approaching from a thousand *li*[3349] away?"

"…!"

"Stop saying foolish things and face reality. Like Brush-Holding Eunuch Ma."

Every head turned toward him at once. Ma Sanbao, who had been listening quietly to the conversation, broke his long silence.

"It's just as I'd expect from the man who nurtured the pillars of the Hanlin Academy. Your mind is as sharp as ever, even past eighty."

"Brush-Holding Eunuch Ma. Then…"

"I agree with His Excellency the Grand Academician."

"…!"

"This is not merely my personal judgment. It is my judgment as the East Depot's Brush-Holding Eunuch."

The others fell silent for a moment. Ma Sanbao had invoked his title as Brush-Holding Eunuch, and that could mean only one thing.

"Then a storm of blood will sweep through the court."

"It will."

Even as someone groaned, Ma Sanbao continued in an unwavering voice.

"But it's already clear whose blood will be caught up in that storm. It's almost upon us, and both sides will have to throw everything they have into the clash."

"Brush-Holding Eunuch Ma. Forgive me for asking, but can we really stand against the Emperor? From what we've learned so far, their forces are far greater than we expected…"

The man regretted speaking almost at once.

Ma Sanbao's gaze had shot toward him, cold and keen as a blade, making his heart sink.

"I—no, forgive me. I misspoke."

He forced out the apology in a voice that would barely come. Ma Sanbao withdrew his gaze as if nothing had happened and replied calmly.

"That was unusually careless of you."

"…"

"We've trusted one another and boarded the same boat. We all have to row together if we're going to get anywhere. Isn't that right?"

"Let me apologize once more. I'm truly sorry."

For a moment, Ma Sanbao's response had chilled the air in the room. But he was also the one who warmed it again.

"Don't worry. We have the justification and the strength to bring the Emperor down."

[3349] A thousand Chinese *li* is about 500 km (310 mi).

“What do you mean…?”

“I can’t tell you everything, but we’ve made ample preparations for this great undertaking. Please understand that I can’t say more than that.”

When Ma Sanbao put it that way, the others quietly folded away the questions lingering on their tongues and tucked them into a corner of their hearts.

The fewer people who knew a secret, the better.

Besides, though each of them had contributed some measure of influence and power, Ma Sanbao was one of the key figures in this plan.

Much like a certain old minister: the Grand Academician of the Hanlin Academy, the cradle of the realm’s talent, who still held sway over the court even after retiring from office.

“By the way, how is that person doing?”

Ma Sanbao immediately understood the meaning behind the sudden question and answered.

“That person is still safe.”

“I’m worried. The Emperor must be watching for an opportunity every chance he gets.”

“But he won’t get what he wants. I’ll say this with confidence: for now, even the Emperor won’t find it easy to lay a hand on that person.”

“The whole Imperial Capital is boiling like a pot left over a fire. Before long, it’ll spill over in every direction.”

“When do you think that will happen, Your Excellency?”

The old minister answered without the slightest hesitation.

“The banquet. The one where the Emperor acknowledged the rumors and made his announcement.”

“I think so too.”

“It’ll be a Hongmen Banquet.[3350] Blades will cross, and lives will hang in the balance.”

“It won’t be the same as Hongmen. Xiang Yu was foolish enough to let Liu Bang live, but the Emperor won’t do that.”

The old minister quietly nodded, lost in thought. Then he suddenly spoke.

“What about that young martial artist? What do you think he’ll do?”

“He’ll help us. Just as we expected.”

“I’ve heard he possesses martial arts far beyond what you’d expect for his age. But there are several masters around the Emperor who are just as strong. Do you think he’ll be much help?”

“Who knows?”

Ma Sanbao continued with a faint smile.

[3350] At the historical Feast at Hong Gate, a banquet became the setting for an attempt on Liu Bang’s life.

“But if his master is there, that changes things.”

Chapter 882

From the day the imperial proclamation went up in the streets, the area around the palace was busier than ever.

People came for all sorts of reasons.

Commoners lingered outside the palace, hoping to catch even a glimpse of the ill-fated young prince they'd heard about only in rumors. Confucian scholars who fancied themselves men of loyalty and righteousness shouted at the top of their lungs, demanding to know why Prince Shangshan had been summoned in secret at a time like this. And poets and writers hoping to land themselves a position took the opportunity to compose and recite poems for the Emperor, who had finally secured an heir.

"How long are we supposed to wait? We can't see a damn thing from here, Prince Shangshan or no Prince Shangshan."

"You fool. Did you think His Highness would come out and say, 'Oh, you're here,' just because we're waiting? We're only here on the off chance he might."

"Fair enough. But why are those high-and-mighty people so desperate to tear each other apart?"

"Perhaps they disagree."

The commoners murmured as they watched two groups of scholars argue, their faces flushed red.

"What? The Emperor having an heir is the Great Nation's good fortune and a joy to all its people? It's toadies like you who are ruining this country!"

"Shut your mouth! How dare you speak like that before His Majesty… Right outside the imperial palace!"

"How is it nonsense? You vermin can see perfectly well what's happening, yet you pretend you can't!"

"What did you say? Vermin? I've heard enough from you, you backwater scholar!"

"You bootlicking son of a bitch! Which academy are you from?"

"So what if you know? What are you going to do about it?"

"You son of a—Everyone! Words won't settle this! Let's drive those toadies out of the Imperial Capital!"

"Yeah!"

Hundreds of scholars hurling fists and inkstones at one another made quite a spectacle.

"Hit them! Hit them!"

"Grab that one first!"

Shouts and screams rang out from every direction. Someone watched the scene with their mouth hanging open, then muttered, “The greatest contest since the founding of the nation.”

But the fierce brawl ended as suddenly as it had begun.

And it wasn’t the imperial guards watching the fight from up close with keen interest who stopped them.

Thud.

Amid the chaos, a scholar backing away with a brush gripped like a dagger felt something touch his back.

Have I already been driven up against a wall?

That couldn’t be right.

The main road in front of the imperial palace was so wide that a hundred grown men could walk abreast without their shoulders touching. Besides, there was nothing nearby that could be called a wall.

And it doesn’t even feel completely hard.

So what was it?

The scholar started to turn around cautiously. At that very moment—

“You rat!”

“Gah!”

“I’ve finally got you—!”

One of the poets and writers, a pair of inkstones in his hands as he raced through the battlefield, charged toward the scholar—and suddenly froze. His mouth slowly fell open as he lifted his head.

Not toward the scholar’s face, only a few paces away, but far above it.

“Uh… uh…”

A dazed voice escaped his lips. At the same time, a huge shadow fell over him.

Step.

A particularly heavy footstep sounded, and something pushed the scholar forward. He gulped, turned around, and finally understood.

What stood behind him had never been a wall.

It was a monstrous man, tall as a wall and hard as a boulder.

“…!”

“…!”

The air, hot with the brawl only moments ago, froze. Everyone gathered along the road outside the imperial palace stared, mouths agape, at the giant who had appeared among them.

What kind of monster is that…?

A shock flashed through everyone’s minds like a bolt of lightning.

The fierce disagreement of moments before was forgotten. They could only stare at a giant unlike any they had seen before—or would ever see again.

Even at a glance, he stood well over nine feet tall.

His limbs were like pillars; a single swing looked as if it could raise a gale. Muscles covered his body like armor, enough to make their knees go weak just looking at him.

And what about the head perched on his thick neck like a great boulder?

Never mind that it was as big as a well-grown pumpkin. Every time those enormous eyes blinked, people felt as though it took years off their lives.

The scholars who, only moments ago, had dared to demand an explanation from the Emperor were especially beside themselves.

Could he be an Embroidered Uniform Guard?

No. The Guard recruits from among ordinary people. That thing isn't human.

A secret weapon! The Emperor raised him to wipe out his opposition!

To hell with loyalty and righteousness. At the sight of that terrifying giant, their hands and feet trembled and their heads went numb.

If they were formally sentenced to drink poison or be beheaded, at least people would call it an honorable death. But if they took even one slap from that hand larger than a pot lid, they'd die like dogs.

And yet…

"Y-You think we'll back down just because of that?!"

The scholar who would go down as the first person to discover the giant—and probably the first person to die at his hands—in the annals of the Great Nation's scholarly world, barely managed to force out a voice that wouldn't come.

"J-Justice still lives! Even if you kill everyone here, the whole world will learn of your wicked plot!"

He was speaking to the giant before him and to the Emperor.

How many years had he spent committing the words of ancient sages to heart, beginning with the Four Books and Three Classics?

There was right and wrong in all things, and a nation could stand only if it upheld the Three Bonds and Five Relationships.[3351] The scholar bit his lip until it bled.

I'd rather die here than spend the rest of my life cowering beneath the Emperor's power!

If he died protecting Prince Shangshan and the world for a great cause, it would be worth it.

His body trembled like an aspen, but his resolve was like bamboo: it would break before it bent. He forced down his fear and looked up at the giant.

[3351] The Three Bonds and Five Relationships are Confucian principles governing social duties. The bonds concern ruler and subject, father and son, and husband and wife; the five relationships also include elder and younger siblings, and friends.

Then he noticed that hundreds of Imperial Guards had surrounded them and knew death was coming.

Until the guards' commander shouted in a trembling voice.

"W-Who are you?!"

"…?"

"…?"

"Id-Identify yourself at once!"

The scholar and everyone else watching blinked.

What the hell?

Weren't they on the same side?

Then what's that monster?

And then—

The giant, who had stood there like an iron wall without saying a word, finally spoke.

His voice was as innocent as a child's.

"I am Taishan—no, Geosan. I don't want to get in trouble. I don't know what I did wrong, but I'm sorry."

"…!"

"…!"

"I just heard a noise and came to watch. Can I go on my way?"

In an instant, the atmosphere, drawn taut as a bowstring, collapsed.

He came to watch? Just to watch?

He's sorry? He doesn't want to get in trouble? He apologizes that easily?

And what's with the way he talks?

Everyone was at a loss for words as the giant blinked slowly, like a young calf.

"Y-You little bastard, I finally found you! Hey! Stand right there! You're built like a damn mountain, so why the hell do you vanish like a squirrel the moment I look away?"

The voice rang through the hushed crowd. A dark-skinned old man who barely reached five feet shoved his way through and ran over. He gave the giant's thigh a sharp smack, then noticed all the eyes fixed on him and froze like a statue.

"…"

"…"

In the awkward silence, the commander of the guards looked back and forth between the young giant and the old dwarf, his eyes gone cold.

"Who exactly are you, old man?"

After a brief silence, the old dwarf answered, "An ordinary traveler passing by. Nothing more."

“You look awfully suspicious. Do you two know each other?”

“Sadly, yes.”

“Then what’s your relationship?”

“I’ve no idea what that idiot thinks of me, but whenever he falls asleep, I try to strangle him. Unfortunately, I’ve failed every time.”

The commander of the Imperial Guards looked at the giant’s neck, thicker than a bull’s, and murmured in understanding.

“You sound even more suspicious now.”

“I hear that a lot. It’s because of the big fellow next to me.”

“Have you ever been arrested by the local authorities because of him?”

“Not once.”

“Then let’s make this your first time. Guards!”

Clang!

Sharp spears and swords flashed in the tightly clenched hands of the guards. The old man let out a deep sigh at their menacing show of force, then spoke.

“Could you wait just a moment?”

The commander’s expression and voice hardened.

“Not a chance. Hand over your identity tag before blood is spilled.”

“My companion has it, so that’s a bit difficult.”

“Then you’ll learn what a truly difficult situation is. And what companion? Is there another accomplice?”

“He’s not an accomplice… Hey, don’t just stand there. Hurry up and call your wet nurse.”

“Wait! Don’t try anything!”

The guards nearby sensed trouble and hurried to stop him, but they were too late to prevent the giant’s shout.

“Fiiive-spiiice poooork!”

The people filling the road outside the imperial palace were startled once by the tremendous shout that battered their ears, then again by the strange words it contained.

Why is he suddenly asking for five-spice pork?

Is he actually crazy?

Even the commander of the Imperial Guards was momentarily confused.

Why was he shouting about five-spice pork out of nowhere? Was the name of those suspicious men’s accomplice Five-Spice Pork? Or had something gone wrong with his ears?

It was none of those things.

The giant had shouted because he wanted five-spice pork right then and there. And his companions had been through this sort of thing so often they were sick of it.

Put simply, they knew better than anyone that there was only one man in the world crazy enough to call for five-spice pork that loudly and desperately outside the imperial palace.

They also knew he was their companion, who had vanished the moment they looked away.

"Tai… no, Geosan!"

At the urgent shout, the crowd parted like a receding tide.

The people who had thought nothing could surprise them anymore found themselves rubbing their eyes again.

A carriage pulled by two horses was racing toward them at a mad pace.

"Whoa! Whoaaaa!"

"Move! Get out of the way!"

The street erupted into chaos. The carriage barely managed to stop when it reached the tense Imperial Guards.

A young man jumped lightly down from it and hurriedly felt over the giant's body.

"Are you all right? Are you hurt anywhere?"

"Hehe, I'm fine. Everything's good except I'm hungry."

The giant answered with a broad grin like a five-year-old's. The onlookers shuddered again, but the commander did not.

He watched people spill out of the little carriage.

What kind of group is this?

There were seven of them in all.

A pretty girl with noticeable freckles, and a young man beside her whose face was as stiff as a log.

A giant who looked like a walking natural disaster, and a young man who handled that mountain of muscle as if it were a delicate piece of porcelain. An old man smiling placidly like an immortal amid all the chaos, and a short, dark-skinned old man beside him muttering curses.

And finally…

Is that a monk?

For some reason, even his eyebrows had been shaved clean off. He was a mean-looking, disreputable monk.

What the hell is going on?

The commander guarded one of the imperial palace's twelve gates and had seen all kinds of things, but he swore he had never seen anything like this.

As he hesitated in confusion, the mean-looking monk, who had been the last to climb down from the carriage, approached and held something out.

“What is this?” the commander asked.

“What is this? You son of a—”

“…?”

“Ah. That slipped out.”

As if trying to hold back his anger, the disreputable monk took a deep breath and continued.

“We’re the circus troupe performing at the banquet. That’s our official letter of introduction.”

“A circus troupe?”

“That’s right. To liven things up, some bigwig or other invited us.”

The commander hurriedly unfolded the letter in his hand. His eyes widened when he saw the seal of a high official—someone far beyond his station to question.

“This is…”

“You’ve seen it, so you know. Open the gate already.”

He might only be a junior officer, but he was a hundred-man commander in the imperial guard, responsible for protecting the capital. To be spoken to like that by a troupe of traveling performers—

But whoever backed the troupe was beyond his ability to deal with. He swallowed his anger and ordered his men to open the gate, committing the troupe’s name on the letter to memory.

The Blazing Flame Troupe? Even the name sounds tacky.

Of course, it never crossed his mind that the monk would have beaten him half to death if he’d said that aloud.

Chapter 883

It was only natural for the imperial palace to be heavily guarded.

But since the current Son of Heaven had taken the throne, its defenses had grown into an impregnable fortress beyond anything the past could compare to.

Ten times as many guards. Security that shut outsiders out completely.

Even a well-known court official couldn't enter or leave without an authorized pass.

Some gossips had dared to call the palace the largest, most splendid prison in the world.

But today, even that derisive nickname aimed at the Emperor seemed out of place.

"Affiliation and name."

"I'm Hong, from Seok Family Manor. Here are the identity tags and inventory of the belongings of the people who came with me."

"Ah, forgive me. You're the steward of Seok Family Manor! Is your Family Head keeping well?"

"Thanks to Your Excellency's concern, he's as hale as ever."

"Ha ha, I'm glad to hear it. We'll have to continue our conversation later. All right, next!"

"Good day. I'm from the Continental Escort Bureau…"

A grand banquet on this scale required a great many supplies and people.

The Outer Palace, the palace's outermost section, was bustling with outsiders—a sight rarely seen there over the past decade. Officials drafted from various departments to prepare for the banquet sorted the arrivals into groups.

Naturally, people were treated differently according to their status and importance.

The wealthy merchants, whose contributions would help fund the imperial treasury and the banquet, received the warmest welcome. Next came those who had brought rare tribute gifts, hoping to make an impression. Far below them were the performers who had come to enliven the festivities.

Circus troupes, for instance, whose livelihoods depended on performing all sorts of feats.

"Damn it. A circus troupe at my age…"

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, muttered as though lamenting his fate.

If the proud ancestors of the Fire Gate Clan had seen him now, they would have wept beneath the earth… or perhaps not.

Unlike those inflexible bastards from the Nine Sects and One Gang, they might be gathered in the heavens right now, peering down through the clouds and snickering.

“Hey, isn’t that Jeok Cheongang fellow over a hundred?”

“He passed a hundred ages ago. He’s probably lived longer than anyone in our sect’s history. Isn’t dying young practically a Fire Gate Clan tradition?”

“That’s what happens when a one-disciple lineage keeps picking the most hotheaded bastards in the land to teach. Anyway, the imperial palace. That ought to be interesting. Who was his master?”

“Me.”

“Me? You still haven’t learned your lesson? When an ancestor as exalted as I am calls on you, how are you supposed to answer?”

“I-I’m sorry.”

“Again.”

“Seventeenth Sect Leader, Hong. Wi. Ryang!”

Something like that, probably.

Imagining his master standing stiffly at attention, Jeok Cheongang felt a lump rise in his throat.

“I’m sorry. I raised my disciple so poorly that even you, Master…”

At the sorrowful sound of his voice, Taishan, standing beside him, spoke with a solemn expression.

“I want five-spice pork.”

“Namho, kill that bastard right now. I’ll allow it.”

“Really? You mean it? I can really do that?”

“No, you can’t!”

Namho eagerly reached for Taishan’s throat, but Sama Pyo hurriedly stopped him.

A few steps away, the Divine Physician watched the scene and chuckled.

“There’s no danger of our identities being exposed. Anyone can see we’re a fine circus troupe.”

Jeok Cheongang gave him a disgruntled look.

“To hell with that. Does it make any sense for me to be in a circus troupe at my age?”

“And what about at my age? At least you look young, Old Master. There’s no mistaking me for anything but an old man.”

“…”

“We’re already here, so what else can we do? Taishan—no, Geosan—is enormous. A circus troupe is about the only cover that won’t raise suspicion.”

For all his complaints, Jeok Cheongang couldn’t disagree.

“That… is true.”

The East Depot might not wield the power it once had, but it could still arrange a wide variety of thoroughly prepared false identities.

Half a day before they entered the palace, however, the East Depot specialist who came to deliver the human-skin masks and identity tags they needed had taken one look at Taishan. After a long silence, he'd asked:

"D-Does this man have to come too?"

"I'd love to leave him behind, but we have no choice. I swear he'd cause trouble if we did. If the Embroidered Uniform Guard caught him, he'd spill everything for one plate of five-spice pork."

"Taishan not that kind of traitor! Taishan wouldn't sell out his friends for just one plate!"

"Fine. Ten plates, then. Extra meat and spices."

"Hmm. Hmmmmm. Taishan needs a little time to think."

"See? That's the bastard we're dealing with."

"Ah…"

"What can we do?"

"We'll have to change your cover. With a man that size, merchants are out of the question. A circus troupe would be best."

"A circus troupe? You want to turn this old man into a street clown?"

"I-I'm sorry, but there's no other way. You're all highly skilled masters. A few feats should be enough to make you look the part."

"Feats? You mean holding oil in your mouth and breathing fire?"

"That's right."

"But that won't be enough for a grand banquet at the imperial palace."

"We've already made arrangements, so you only need to look convincing. That large fellow will draw particular attention, though. To be safe, he should practice a few feats beforehand."

"Feats. Such as?"

"As you said, holding oil in his mouth and…"

"That bastard doesn't keep anything in his mouth. Whatever goes in, he chews up and swallows without mercy."

"Then… tearing firewood apart with his bare hands…"

"That won't be a problem. He tears people apart with his hands."

"…Please never say things like that inside the imperial palace. You absolutely must promise me."

After the specialist's desperate, repeated warnings, Jeok Cheongang, the Divine Physician, and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members had received new names and faces and been allowed into the imperial palace.

Of course, there was no doubt the East Depot's immense power had made it possible.

“So everything in the letter was true. I can’t believe we got into that magnificent imperial palace so easily.”

At Jeok Cheongang’s mutter, the pretty, freckled girl beside him—who had been looking around carefully—answered.

“It was probably easier because this is the Outer Palace. Security at the Inner Palace is on another level. The Imperial Guards protecting the Outer Palace are elite soldiers, but the Inner Palace is guarded by the Embroidered Uniform Guard, the Emperor’s personal guard.”

“How do you know so much?”

“My grandfather told me. The imperial family entrusted him with several important jobs a long time ago.”

“Huh. I suppose that makes sense, given that he’s the Escort King. And you remember stories you heard as a child remarkably well.”

Jeok Cheongang looked at Ju Hwaran with an affection he never showed anyone else. A faint smile touched her face, tense until now.

That was when someone called out.

“Is everyone here?”

A court official swept an arrogant gaze over the gathering. His loose robes did nothing to hide his bulk or the belly that bulged like a well-fed pig’s.

“As the official in charge of the music for this grand banquet, I will inspect and sort you all before the festivities begin.”

Clank. Clank.

A heavy metallic sound rang out the moment he finished speaking.

The newcomers wore gleaming golden armor and carried an aura far more imposing than that of any Imperial Guards the group had seen so far. The other circus troupes who had come to perform at the banquet, along with the courtesans and musicians, swallowed nervously.

“The Embroidered Uniform Guard…”

There was no mistaking them.

Permitted to wear gold, one of the Son of Heaven’s symbols, they were the Great Nation’s finest troops. Alongside the East Depot, they were its most powerful watchers.

Unlike the Imperial Guards, who could be seen throughout the Imperial Capital, the Embroidered Uniform Guard rarely appeared. When they did, their authority was unmistakable.

As formidable as the man who now stepped forward, his eyes gleaming.

“I am Jeong Hogun, a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.”

His voice was calm, but a heavy aura pressed down in every direction.

Jeok Cheongang sensed his intent well before that wave of energy reached the crowd and swiftly sent a Sound Transmission.

—Everyone, be on your guard.

The inspection and sorting the fat official had mentioned would be neither ordinary nor easy.

They're using the Embroidered Uniform Guard to weed out possible assassins.

Flies always gathered around a well-laid feast.

It would be one thing if they were merely a nuisance. Flies armed with swords and spears and aiming for the Emperor's life were another matter entirely.

Fortunately, Jeok Cheongang's group and the East Depot had anticipated this.

I knew it.

Know your enemy and know yourself, and you can fight a hundred battles without peril.

To prepare for just such a situation, the Divine Physician had personally made Energy-Dispersing Poison, which disrupted internal energy, and given it to the group. Jeok Cheongang had already reached the realm of Returning to Simplicity and could conceal his qi at will without it.

The only problem is that bastard Taishan…

But contrary to his fears, Jeong Hogun's gaze rested on Taishan only briefly before moving away.

Or rather, trouble broke out elsewhere before he could examine Taishan closely.

"You there. Step forward."

"M-Me, sir?"

The sparrow-mustached man, who looked like the steward of a pleasure house, asked in a trembling voice. Jeong Hogun shook his head.

"No. The courtesan behind you."

"W-Whatever could be the reason…?"

"She knows better than I do. Don't you?"

The courtesan, who looked barely twenty, had a pure, lovely face. She blinked in surprise, then threw herself face-first onto the ground.

"T-This girl has done nothing wrong!"

Jeong Hogun replied flatly.

"I think so too."

"Th-Then why…?"

"But the sachet at your waist smells of bitter poison."

"…!"

"Will you explain yourself?"

The courtesan raised her head and stared up at Jeong Hogun in bewilderment.

Then she yanked the hairpin from her hair and swung it in a flash.

Whoosh! Thunk!

A faint sound of air being cut, followed by a spray of blood.

Jeong Hogun watched with a lowered gaze as the courtesan plunged the hairpin into her own neck.

“Why?”

“T-Twelve years ago. Grrk. My father and mother, my younger sibling… Cough.”

“Revenge. Yes, I suppose so.”

“The Emperor… I have to k-kill…”

Thump.

Still coughing up blood, the courtesan went limp and collapsed.

Jeong Hogun stared down at the corpse in silence for a while, then spoke abruptly.

“Remove the body. Take everyone who came with her to the prison.”

“Yes, sir!”

“W-Wait! We didn’t know anything about this! We really don’t know a thing…”

Clang-clang!

The cold sound of drawn blades drowned out their desperate excuses.

Realizing they had no choice, they disappeared somewhere under the Embroidered Uniform Guard’s escort, faces filled with despair.

Jeong Hogun watched until they were gone, then turned to the person he had put off questioning.

“You there.”

“Huh?”

“You said you belonged to a circus troupe.”

“Yeah.”

Taishan looked around blankly. Jeok Cheongang lowered his head, weighing whether to wait a little longer or step in himself.

Just as he cautiously curled his hand into a fist, a voice from far away reached his ears.

“Oh, Hogun. What are you doing here?”

At the familiar voice, Jeok Cheongang reflexively raised his head.

A young man was walking toward them with a wide grin.

Chapter 884

The moment I saw what was happening, I thought:

I knew this would happen.

It wasn't as if I were some gifted shaman who'd come rushing over because a divine spirit told me to. I'd decided I should see for myself as soon as Hong Jin gave me the news.

"People from Young Master Jin's group entered the palace a little while ago. Disguised as a circus troupe. But…"

"Did something go wrong?"

"I think so. They seem to have attracted more attention than we expected. You know that huge man in the group?"

"Ah, fuck. I told them not to do that."

"…I haven't even said anything yet."

"What's the point? I know what they're usually like. I'd better go take a look."

Wait. Eunuch Ma must have made arrangements. Let's give it a little longer.

"I know my companions better than anyone. Even if it's only to be safe, I should see for myself."

"Captain, you're absolutely right. I'll escort you and have you back in no time, so Comrade Hong can relax."

"Mujin."

"Yes, Captain."

"Quit showing off and stay here."

"…"

"That bastard would only go and cause another mess."

I'd left the pavilion without a moment's hesitation half an hour ago.

For some reason, ever since I'd met the Emperor two days earlier, the Embroidered Uniform Guard surrounding the pavilion had only watched from a distance. They hadn't tried to stop me. And the place Hong Jin had told me about was much closer than I'd expected.

I'd had to take a roundabout route to avoid looking suspicious, but fortunately, I'd arrived just in time.

Right now.

"Oh, Hogun. What are you doing here?"

At my casual greeting, the air around us, taut as a bowstring, eased.

Then every eye turned to me. Among the faces were a few that looked unfamiliar and familiar at the same time.

I don't know if those are human-skin masks or what, but they've done a hell of a job with the disguise technique.

The smallest change to someone's features could give them a completely different look.

Pretending to sweep my gaze over the crowd, I spotted my companions huddled in one corner. Then I waved to Jeong Hogun.

"There's an old saying that you can't spit in a smiling face, but looking at you, Hogun, I guess that isn't always true. Could you at least answer when someone speaks to you?"

Jeong Hogun opened his mouth, his expression subdued.

"Who are you calling 'our Hogun'?"

"Fine, then. Your Hogun."

"As always, it's impossible to have a sensible conversation with you."

"What's the point of a bunch of smelly, black balls understanding each other? Are you interested in me, by any chance?"

"Not at all. But I am interested in why you've suddenly appeared here."

That was the Embroidered Uniform Guard for you.

His tone was blunt, but the meaning behind it was sharp as a needle. Still, I hadn't spent all my time stumbling around Murim training only my martial skills.

And the half hour I'd spent getting here had given me plenty of time to think about how to avoid the enemy's suspicion—and what to do if I drew it anyway.

"What the hell do you mean, why? I was bored and taking a walk nearby. Things looked tense, so I came over."

I pointed to the blood splattered across the ground. It had to have come from someone.

"Thought I might find something, and sure enough."

"…"

"On my way here, I saw about fifteen people being dragged off in a line. What did they do, commit treason?"

Jeong Hogun stared at me for a long while without answering, then abruptly spoke.

"They were trying to attend the banquet disguised as courtesans."

I wasn't lying about seeing people dragged away.

I remembered the corpse one of the Embroidered Uniform Guard had hauled off, rolled up in a straw mat. That was probably the courtesan Jeong Hogun meant.

I wonder why she did it.

I had no way of knowing. She might have survived the destruction of her family at the Emperor's hands, or she might have been an assassin sent by someone who considered themselves a champion of loyalty and righteousness.

There were plenty of possibilities. The problem was that the incident had put Jeong Hogun even more on edge. He might start suspecting my companions.

This can't be how things go from the start.

I spoke as naturally as I could, with the same hint of contempt in my eyes and voice I'd used until now.

"You brought down a traitor who dared raise a blade against His Majesty the Emperor. You're definitely getting promoted this time, Thousand Captain Jeong."

"I didn't kill her. She took her own life."

"It's basically the same thing. Why do you think she killed herself? Because being dragged off and tortured to death would've been worse. She'd failed anyway, so dying cleanly was a hundred, a thousand times better. You know that too, don't you?"

Jeong Hogun was silent for a moment, then answered evenly.

"Yes. You're right."

What?

He'd always been like that, but there was something strange about how little my sharp words seemed to affect him. I wondered to myself,

Has he noticed something?

His instincts seemed sharper than those of the other Embroidered Uniform Guards. I couldn't rule it out, and if he had noticed something, I couldn't leave things as they were.

I smiled broadly and stepped forward.

"Nice to see you admit I'm right for once. How about I lend you a hand while I'm here?"

"You want to help?"

"It's easy enough. Who knows? If I catch a traitor even the Embroidered Uniform Guard couldn't weed out, maybe His Majesty the Emperor will grant me a wish."

"What are you up to?"

"There you go again. That's an occupational disease, you know. At this stage, even the Divine Physician couldn't cure you."

Thank goodness every eye was on me.

I pretended not to notice the Divine Physician flinching on reflex among the crowd, then shrugged at Jeong Hogun.

"Anyway, say the word if you don't want my help. Otherwise, I'll take a quick look around. I'm better at that sort of thing than you are. You know that."

I wasn't just saying that.

Jeong Hogun was far better at surveillance and interrogation, but when it came to judging someone's martial skill, I was a step ahead of him. I'd crossed the threshold of Supreme Peak, after all.

No—if I could use Qi Sense, which I couldn't right now, to get precise information, I'd be the perfect person for the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Of course, my offer probably sounded strange to everyone else.

—Is this madman serious…?

—What are you plotting?

Two Sound Transmissions reached me in succession. The first came from Jeok Cheongang. The second came from Jeong Hogun.

I gave a quiet laugh and replied in kind, addressing only the man staring at me as though determined not to miss the slightest opening.

—Why bother with Sound Transmission? It's not that big a deal.

—Answer me properly. Why are you doing this?

—Why? Isn't it obvious?

I looked Jeong Hogun straight in the eye and moved my lips.

—What if some lunatic starts swinging a sword at the banquet? And what if that stern Emperor you love so much gets hurt? Who do you think's going to take the blame for it all?

—…!

—I'm not doing this for the master you serve. I'm doing it to protect His Highness Prince Shangshan, you idiot.

It was an explanation that made perfect sense from start to finish. I'd come up with it in a hurry on the way here, but it worked.

The muscles in Jeong Hogun's rigid face relaxed, if only a little.

Success.

But I wasn't finished.

I swallowed the sigh of relief that was about to escape me, clicked my tongue, and turned away.

—From what I can see, there's no one particularly suspicious right now. Just do your job properly from here on out. Both of us have someone to protect, don't we?

That was it.

I walked back the way I'd come, at an easy pace, crossing through the now-quiet crowd. I didn't forget to pause and react when I reached Taishan, whose face had changed but whose massive build hadn't.

"Whoa, damn. Look at the size of you. What on earth do you eat to get that big?"

Taishan answered haltingly.

"I like… I like five-spice pork."

"Liar."

"…Huh?"

"You look like you'd eat anything."

"Oh. Uh, yeah. I do."

"Those muscles and bones of yours are ridiculous. You've trained in external arts, haven't you?"

"Geosan. Sold to circus troupe when young. Had to learn to survive."

Circus troupes traveled the land putting on shows. You could find one in just about any sizable city, and there was nothing strange about performers who pushed their bodies so hard learning external arts.

What's strange is how huge he is to begin with.

I thought to myself, then ran my hands over Taishan's arms and legs, which were packed with muscle.

"With a build like this, you could beat most First Rate masters with your fists… Where are you from?"

Namho, an old man with dark skin standing beside us, promptly bowed and answered.

"We're based north of the Yangtze, sir. We mostly perform in Hebei and Liaoning Province."

"Oh, that's close. If you're interested, stop by the Jin Family of Taiyuan in Shanxi Province sometime. He may have missed his chance, but if he has enough internal energy to back it up, he could still become a great martial artist."

"We're grateful for the offer, but we'd rather not. As you can see, he's not as bright as most, but he's the treasure of our circus troupe…"

His time in the Hidden Shadow Pavilion had certainly made Namho a hell of an improviser.

Namho was showing the kind of acting that could kick one of Chungmuro's[3352] rising stars in the shins. After exchanging a few more words with him, I left with an exaggeratedly disappointed look.

Inside, I was certain.

That did it.

Anyone who'd heard us would now know that the giant had learned enough external arts to defeat a First Rate master, that his troupe performed north of the Yangtze, far from the Imperial Capital, and that there wasn't much reason to suspect them.

And the potbellied official turned out to be an ally I hadn't even known about.

"If there's nothing more to investigate, let them through. They've already been thoroughly vetted several times, and I have a mountain of work to do."

Hong Jin's words flashed through my mind.

Wait. Eunuch Ma must have made arrangements. Let's give it a little longer.

Those words hadn't been a lie.

[3352] Chungmuro is a district of Seoul whose name is used as a shorthand for the South Korean film industry.

Rather than draw attention by mobilizing the East Depot, Ma Sanbao must have planted an ally where no one would notice.

Luckily, my arrival fit right in.

After I'd walked a little over ten jang,[3353] my keen hearing picked up Jeong Hogun's blunt voice.

"Let them through."

I cheered inwardly, then found myself at a loss for words when a Sound Transmission came from Jeok Cheongang.

—As expected, you had a plan all along. This old man never doubted you.

—…

No, Old Master.

A moment ago, you called me a madman.

[3353] A *jang* is ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet; a little over ten jang is a little over 30.3 meters or 99.4 feet.

Chapter 885

Naturally, there was no moving reunion beyond that.

We'd only been apart for a few days, and we couldn't exactly acknowledge each other here.

There'll be a chance soon enough.

I crossed the vast grounds of the imperial palace, taking in the layout of the buildings, the Imperial Guards posted everywhere, and the outsiders brought in to prepare for the banquet.

That was when I noticed something unexpected.

What's that?

I stopped and narrowed my eyes at a group carrying boxes about ten paces ahead.

"Hold on. Take that this way."

"One, two. Hup!"

"Those are offerings from Grandee Guanglu.[3354] They're worth more than all your lives put together, so handle them carefully."

"Yes, sir. Of course."

Their clothes were clean but old and mended in places. Hardship had etched lines into their faces.

Sweat poured off them as they bowed and smiled at a man who looked like a low-ranking official, then went straight back to hauling the mountains of goods. They looked like ordinary laborers living from one day's wages to the next.

But…

They're different.

I could feel a faint wrongness about them. It was an instinct honed through countless real battles and brushes with death—so subtle that I wouldn't have noticed it if I hadn't reached my current realm.

They're not ordinary laborers.

I couldn't sense any internal energy from them, but one thing gave them away.

The stench of blood.

It was like a brand no amount of washing could remove. The sour smell of sweat and the mustiness of old clothes couldn't quite cover it.

Martial artists?

Were they martial artists who'd voluntarily taken Energy-Dispersing Poison to hide their internal energy? Or was it just my imagination, brought on by the fact that I had to be sensitive to everything happening around me right now?

I'll know if I check.

[3354] *Guanglu dafu* was an honorific rank for senior officials in imperial China.

I started toward them for a closer look—or tried to.

A cart, unable to bear its load, tipped toward me.

Crack. Crash!

Wooden splinters flew. Silver yuanbao[3355] and all kinds of ornaments spilled from the boxes, and the official clutched his head.

“What the hell do you think you’re doing?”

“I-I’m sorry. I loaded the cart wrong, and…”

“You stupid old fool! Forget apologizing and pick it all up! If even one thing is damaged, you’ll pay dearly!”

“Yes, sir. Right away.”

An old man bowed so low he looked ready to snap as the official stormed off. Small and gaunt as a tree that had lost all its life, he limped over and looked up at me with frightened eyes.

“Are you all right, sir? This old man’s mistake didn’t hurt you, did it…?”

A mistake. Sure.

“I’m fine. Not a scratch.”

“Phew. Thank goodness.”

“It gave me a fright, though. That cart looked perfectly sound before it suddenly fell over.”

He saw my smile and bowed again, flustered.

“I apologize once more, sir.”

“Don’t worry about it. Want some help? Looks like there’s a lot to pick up.”

“Oh, how could I ask that of you? It’s more than I deserve that someone of your standing would speak so politely to me…”

“I’m not someone of high standing. You know that already, don’t you?”

For an instant, something shifted among the laborers coming over to clear the mess. In a pause too brief for anyone else to notice, the old man slowly opened his mouth.

“If you’d help us, we’d be very grateful.”

“Then that’s settled.”

I nodded, crouched down, and began gathering the scattered goods. I worked in silence as though picking them up had been my only intention, but I kept my eyes on the old man.

He broke the silence first.

“How did you know?”

I let out a quiet laugh at the admission.

“You gave that up fast.”

[3355] A *yuanbao* was a silver or gold ingot used as currency in imperial China; its value depended on its weight.

“I hate wasting time. Especially when I’m an old man without much of it left.”

“Are you a martial artist? Who do you belong to?”

“Answering a question with a question is rude. Remember that.”

“What does that—oh.”

“How did you know? I was sure no one would notice.”

His eyes gleamed now, the frightened laborer gone as if he’d never existed.

“The stench of blood,” I said.

He didn’t look surprised. He frowned, sniffed at various parts of himself, and smacked his lips.

“My nose must be failing with age. All I smell is old-man stink.”

“That’s there too. Since you brought it up, could we put a little distance between us? I’m having trouble breathing.”

“I thought you were just skilled in martial arts, but you’ve got a hell of a nose, too.”

“You know me?”

“Of course. Information is essential in this line of work. But even without being told about you, I’d have known right away.”

“How?”

The stench of blood.

That shut me up. The old man went on.

“Didn’t you know? You reek of it yourself. Enough that no one would blink if they called you a Killing Ghost instead of a Divine Dragon.”

“…!”

“No need to look at me like that. I mean it as a compliment. You know what they say.”

He grinned, releasing a terrible stench from between his blackened, yellow teeth.

“Kill a hundred and you’re a Killing Ghost. Kill a thousand and they call you a hero. Kill ten thousand and you become… a king.”

My mouth felt gritty, like I’d been chewing sand. I stared at the old man, whose breath stank right in my face.

What the hell is this?

Something about him felt wrong. Just facing him sent a chill down my spine. Even in Murim, with every sort of person roaming it, you rarely came across someone like this.

“Who are you? No—who are all of you?”

“You address a Senior of Murim as ‘you’? Does your master know his Disciple has such poor manners?”

“Someone I met recently told me it was rude to answer a question with a question.”

The old man stared at me, eyes wide, then burst out laughing.

"Well, you got me there."

"Finished laughing? Then answer me."

"Why ask when you already know? Those children and I are martial artists. Not so different from you."

"I'd say you're very different. Am I imagining it?"

"There's no need to worry. We may not belong to the Murim Alliance, but we're in the same boat."

"What does that…"

I trailed off as a thought struck me.

"No way…"

"Eunuch Ma. Is that answer enough?"

"…!"

"Everyone has their own place and role. Go back and wait for the right moment. Any more attention will only make things troublesome."

The old man rose and bowed to me.

"We can manage the rest, sir. You needn't trouble yourself any longer."

It was a clear dismissal—and a performance for whoever might be watching us. No, calling it a performance almost did him a disservice. He *was* an old laborer, every movement perfectly in character.

"Please get back safely, sir. Then this old servant will be off…"

Step. Step.

I watched him limp away carrying a box, and at last I thought I knew what the people disguised as laborers were.

Even in all of Murim, only a few sorts of people could hide themselves and move about so completely. Add that stubborn stench of blood, and only one word came to mind.

Assassins.

Even martial artists, surrounded as they were by lunatics and people with no sense of self-preservation, had certain sorts they preferred to avoid. The same few always made the list.

Killing Ghosts. Fiends. Mysterious old men. Beautiful women in veils.

Like Japan's legendary first-string team, they weren't easy to find. But martial artists with a shred of sense and dreams of retiring to a village for the elderly someday knew to steer clear.

Why? Simple.

Even messing with them—and sometimes just being near them—made a sense of doom creep over you.

And right up there with Killing Ghosts and fiends, among the three most avoided professions, were assassins.

The three kings of utter bastards.

Nobody argued with the list. Plenty of people even put assassins at the top. Someone close to me had once given me much the same advice.

His sobriquet was the Slaughter Saint, which made it a little ironic.

Actually, that's well past ironic. It's practically black comedy.

I kept walking as I muttered to myself. It suddenly occurred to me that I didn't know where this road led. But that thought was quickly buried by the conversation with the Slaughter Saint that came to mind.

"A Killing Ghost or a fiend would be better. But whatever you do, stay away from assassins."

"Why? Aren't they all the same kind of lunatic?"

"Your head is a solid lump of rock, so let me give you a simple example. Say you're eating at an inn and a Killing Ghost or fiend suddenly walks in. What do you do?"

"That'd be fucking awful. I'm trying to eat."

"Well… you're not wrong. But think a little harder before answering."

"You just called me a blockhead. I don't want to think. Can't you tell me?"

"In case you've forgotten, I can break rocks with my fist. A head made of stone is no exception."

"I spoke too soon. May I have a moment to think?"

"You've gotten a little smarter."

"Thank you. Hmm. First, I'd watch the Killing Ghost or fiend, then carefully…"

"Yes. Your first priority is to carefully get out of there."

"No. I'd hit them first."

"…What the hell did the Fire King teach you?"

The Slaughter Saint had looked up at the sky and sighed. Then he'd hit me on the head a couple of times with that rock-breaking fist before continuing.

"To put it more simply, Killing Ghosts and fiends are no different from madmen who don't think about the consequences."

"Ow, my head. Doesn't that make them more dangerous? Like you said, if I met one at an inn, the whole place could turn into a sea of blood."

"But you'd still have a good chance of surviving."

"Well, sure, if your martial skill is high enough…"

"It has nothing to do with skill. You can never predict people like that. They kill or spare people on a whim."

"They really are crazy."

"But what about an assassin?"

"An assassin… Oh."

“Now you’re beginning to understand. They aren’t merely madmen. They’ll do anything to kill their target. That’s how an assassin can kill a master a level or two above them.”

“They’ll do anything to assassinate their target…”

“That’s why you must be most wary of assassins and keep your distance. Understood?”

“Yes. Understood.”

“They’ve lost their place in the world, so you won’t find many these days. Still… what are you doing?”

“Packing my things.”

“Why?”

“You told me to stay away from assassins.”

“…!”

“Oh. Does that not include former assassins?”

Man, I got beaten up a lot that day.

Then again, that was why I remembered the advice so clearly. And now I’d run into those very assassins in the middle of the imperial palace.

If Ma Sanbao was going to bring in martial artists, why bring assassins into the imperial palace?

Just as a question I couldn’t answer right away rose in my mind—

“Stop.”

A clear, bright voice pierced my ears.

Chapter 886

“Stop.”

The clear, bright voice was the last thing I expected to hear. Instinct surged ahead of thought and took over my body.

Whoosh.

I blurred into motion, closing the three-zhang[3356] gap in an instant. My hand shot out, obeying instinct.

Toward the owner of that voice.

Toward her snow-white neck.

Whoom.

The wind, unable to keep up with my speed, arrived a beat late. With a heavy whoosh, her hair fluttered.

At the last moment, I fought down my instincts and stopped my hand in midair. I stared at the familiar face before me.

“What is it?”

“That’s what I’d like to ask you.”

So Gyo glanced at my hand, halted just in front of her throat.

“Striking out of nowhere like that. You’re as rash as you look.”

“I think you mean *more* rash than I look.”

“No, I think I had it right. Now, when do you plan to move that menacing hand?”

“When I’m sure.”

“Sure of what?”

Instead of answering, I sent the internal energy I’d drawn up spreading in every direction.

The System update had sealed my Skills, but that didn’t mean I’d lost the Qi Sense that was part of me as a martial artist.

Whoooosh.

The air rippled like water. I swept a radius of thirty or so zhang[3357] in an instant. Finding no one else nearby, I slowly lowered my hand.

Only then did my heartbeat begin to settle.

If this had been a trap…

Shit.

I’d let my guard down. Lost in thought, I hadn’t even noticed someone nearby. If I’d walked into a trap, I’d have had no excuse.

[3356] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three zhang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); thirty zhang are about 90.9 m (298 ft).

[3357] A zhang is a traditional Chinese unit of length, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three zhang are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft); thirty zhang are about 90.9 m (298 ft).

More importantly… why is she here?

As far as I knew, So Gyo was one of the Emperor's people and stayed in Qianqing Palace.

For a moment, I wondered if I'd wandered deep into the Inner Palace without realizing it. I shook my head.

Impossible.

The boundary between the Outer Palace and Inner Palace was like the difference between heaven and earth. No matter how much freedom I'd been given to move around, I couldn't have entered the Inner Palace unless every member of the Embroidered Uniform Guard protecting it had taken a group nap like golden retrievers at doggy daycare.

And even lost in thought, I couldn't have passed all those people in the Inner Palace without noticing them.

Then I'm still in the Outer Palace. Was there a place like this inside the imperial palace?

I looked around.

Exotic flowers and rare plants crowded the grounds. Beside them lay a moss-covered pond, and at the center of it all stood a huge pavilion, rising like a mountain.

For all its size, the place felt desolate. There wasn't another soul in sight besides So Gyo.

"Where are we?"

I hadn't expected her to answer, but she proved me wrong.

"Forbidden ground."

"Forbidden?"

"A place in the imperial palace no one wants to enter, and everyone keeps quiet about."

"Two people have entered it already."

"Do you not know the difference between *won't* and *can't*?"

"Oh."

"This place was abandoned long ago. No one tries to come near it, so there's no one to guard it."

"Not even against outsiders like me?"

"Only thoroughly vetted people can enter the imperial palace. Even an outsider who doesn't know this place exists wouldn't stray this far if he had the slightest bit of common sense."

"So you're saying I'm an idiot with no common sense?"

"Thank you for saying it yourself."

She got me there.

But thanks to what she'd said earlier, I thought I could guess where I'd wandered by chance.

"Does the reason no one comes here have something to do with what happened a little over ten years ago?"

"…!"

"Your face tells me I'm right."

So Gyo's expression, composed until now, shifted ever so slightly. She regarded me with surprise, then gave a small nod.

"You're more perceptive than you look."

"This time, I think you meant *as* perceptive as I look."

"I said it right. Just like a moment ago."

Rather than snap back, I took another look at the desolate grounds.

So this is the place.

Something had seemed wrong from the moment I saw it. There was no one around, and the grounds had been neglected to an almost shocking degree.

But now I understood, at least somewhat.

If this was where the late Emperor and his direct descendants had been confined after the rebellion more than ten years ago, no one in the imperial palace would dare come near it.

But…

"Why are *you* here?"

That part made no sense. Why would So Gyo, one of the Emperor's loyal followers, come to a place that was practically his sorest point? And why had she answered my questions so readily when I was all but her enemy?

"Don't tell me…"

"I didn't follow you. I thought we'd meet again soon, but I never expected it to be here."

"Then why are you here?"

"Why should I tell you?"

"Well…"

I was at a loss for words and could only smack my lips. Then So Gyo, who had been watching me with composed eyes, suddenly spoke.

"Answer one question honestly, and I might tell you."

"What?"

"I promise."

What the hell was this woman after?

I thought it over for a moment, but I didn't hesitate long. There was something I really wanted to know.

"In exchange, can I ask you something else?"

"Of course."

I still couldn't read what lay behind her calm expression. I frowned at her, then let out a small sigh.

"Let's hear your question first. What do you want to know?"

"It's simple."

Her next words left me even more confused than before.

"How long have you been learning martial arts?"

"What…?"

"I mean exactly what I said. I asked when you started learning martial arts."

For a moment, all I could do was blink.

Her question was so far from anything I'd expected that I'd been keeping my expression in check for nothing. I'd been prepared for something like *How deep are you in with Ma Sanbao?* Instead, the tension drained out of me, leaving only bewilderment.

"No, why would you suddenly ask that…?"

"Have you already forgotten our conversation a moment ago? You only need to answer honestly."

She had a point.

I could tell her the truth. I had no idea why she wanted to know, but the answer couldn't hurt me or any of my allies.

The problem was…

Who'd believe me?

I'd spent my time going back and forth between Murim and the modern world. Even adding the time I'd spent in both worlds together, it came to barely two years.

Who would believe I'd reached my current realm in just two years?

Even the handful of people who knew the truth hadn't fully believed it. They'd simply let it pass, thinking there must be some circumstances behind it.

Even Jeok Cheongang, who'd watched me more closely and for longer than anyone else.

He didn't fully accept it until he learned about the System and the modern world.

The idea that a Third Rate punk steeped in pleasure had become a Supreme Peak master who shook the Central Plains in only two years was simply beyond the bounds of what anyone could accept.

That was why rumors nowhere near the truth had become accepted as fact.

—Jin Taekyung is a secret weapon the Jin Family of Taiyuan raised at the cost of the family's survival.

—They had him pretend to be a layabout from an early age so he wouldn't catch the eye of the Mount Heng Sword Sect or the Head Elder.

—They funneled money to him under the pretense of paying a pleasure house. God knows how many elixirs they bought him with it. Jin Taekyung has three legs, they say.

That last one was a little strange, but anyway.

Rumors like that hadn't sprung up for no reason. Becoming a Supreme Peak master in two years was impossible even if the heavens split in two, so the wild stories had quickly hardened into accepted fact. That suited me.

If I told the truth outright, I could be branded an irredeemable practitioner of demonic, heterodox arts—or worse, an enemy of all Murim who'd mastered terrifying demonic martial arts.

And if I tell So Gyo the truth, she won't believe me anyway.

As far as I could tell, she was a First Rate martial artist herself.

Sometimes what *looks* true matters more than the whole truth.

Like now.

"Fifteen years."

I met So Gyo's eyes without a flicker of change in my expression.

"The story going around is that I caught a tiger with a pinecone when I was one, and learned the art of shrinking space when I was two… but that's a load of bullshit only idiots believe. Going by the memories I still have, it's been about fifteen years."

So Gyo murmured, "Fifteen years."

"You might not know this, but I have a brother just a few years older than me. I trained hard while he knocked me around. I had talent, too, of course."

"Like Cheongpung, the Huashan Divine Dragon?"

"Right. Cheongpung—wait. You know him? Even his title?"

"I know far more than you think. I've kept up with news from Murim."

"No, I mean, why would you need to?"

"There's someone I need to find. Someone I absolutely must find."

So Gyo answered calmly and turned away.

Or rather, she was about to when I shot out an arm as fast as lightning.

"I answered, so you need to keep your promise—"

And then—

Swish. Rustle.

A breeze passed between us.

"Huh?"

I stood frozen like a statue, staring dumbly at the hem of her robe as it brushed past my fingertips.

What was that?

I hadn't used my full strength, but I'd moved more than fast enough to catch a First Rate martial artist.

Yet So Gyo had slipped past my hand with a movement technique so smooth she seemed to glide. As though it were the most natural thing in the world.

Was that just my imagination? Or...

A thought took shape in my mind, and the blood in my body seemed to turn cold. I glared at So Gyo, my eyes sinking deep.

"I didn't know you could do that."

"I can do quite a few things. Just as you can see."

"Your movement technique is definitely beyond First Rate... Are you good at lying, getting under people's skin, and running off, too?"

"Lying? I don't think you're in a position to accuse me of that."

"What?"

"You said you've been learning martial arts for fifteen years. Every word of it was a lie."

"...!"

"Don't underestimate the imperial family's intelligence network. That's why I'm staying here, too."

A chill ran down my spine.

Her calm eyes seemed to pierce straight through me. And I had a feeling So Gyo wasn't merely one of the Emperor's loyal followers.

"You... what are you, exactly?"

Ssshhh.

Three jiazi[3358] of Scorching Yang Qi heated the air around me.

[3358] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle; three jiazi equal 180 years.

Chapter 887

Sssshhh.

Heat like molten lava surged through countless acupoints, setting them ablaze.

I glared at So Gyo with burning eyes. My voice came out dry as ash.

“You… what the hell are you?”

“That’s quite a reaction. You should calm down and settle your internal energy before you overdo it.”

So Gyo—or rather, the woman whose identity I no longer knew—answered with her usual composure. But she’d dropped the polite speech and courteous manner she’d used to keep up appearances.

Then her next words hit me like a surging tide.

“Especially considering the state you’re in right now. Don’t you think?”

“…!”

Was this what it felt like to have lightning strike through the top of your head?

My voice trembled before I could stop it.

“H-How?”

“Your internal energy isn’t flowing steadily.”

Her answer was short, simple, and impossible to argue with.

But that wasn’t why I’d lost my words. For her to give such an obvious answer, one thing had to be true.

Qi Sense.

Exceptionally keen Qi Sense, sharp as a blade.

Every fight began with gauging your opponent. A master could see how much internal energy a lesser martial artist possessed and what condition it was in, but the lesser martial artist couldn’t accurately gauge the master’s level.

And right now, I was unmistakably the latter.

A master!

There was no doubt. So Gyo was an incredible master.

A Supreme Peak master who’d reached the realm of Returning to Simplicity—able to hide herself so perfectly that even I couldn’t see through her.

So that movement earlier wasn’t a fluke.

I suppressed the sigh threatening to escape and quietly clenched my fists.

I had no weapon worth mentioning, and my body was in rough shape. No matter how optimistically I looked at it, I was in no condition to face a master a level above me.

Still, I lowered my stance at an angle and drew up my internal energy again.

“Who are you?”

So Gyo answered calmly.

“I have no obligation to tell you. You were the one who broke your promise and lied first, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

“Shut the fuck up and answer me. Whose orders are you following? The Emperor’s? Or…”

I glared at her and spat out two words.

“Lord of Heaven?”

“Who knows.”

A brief silence followed. So Gyo studied me with an expression I couldn’t read, then spoke again.

“If you knew who I was, what would that change?”

“It would change things. Lives are at stake.”

“Lives…”

“Yeah. Depending on your answer, someone here is definitely going to die.”

“If it comes to that, we already know who it’ll be. Don’t we?”

At that moment—

Sssshhh.

The air trembled. Her aura stirred the grass and flowers like a north wind, while her cold gaze and voice wrapped around me like winter frost.

But I didn’t waver.

I’d been through too many bloodbaths to fear someone just because she was strong—as a Hunter and as a martial artist of Murim.

“Yeah, maybe it’s already been decided to some extent. But who says only one of us has to die?”

“What?”

“I’ll kill you. No matter what.”

“…!”

“I swear on everything I have. No—I guarantee it.”

My voice was so calm it surprised even me.

This wasn’t a desperate bluff from a weaker fighter backed into a corner. So Gyo could tell I meant every word.

“You… you’re serious?”

“Of course.”

“So you’re willing to die taking me with you. Ha.”

She gave a short, disbelieving laugh and looked me up and down like some strange animal.

“So the reports were true after all. I suppose you must have something up your sleeve to have survived this long.”

"The Blood Lord, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, and most recently, even the Southern Heaven Demon Empress. The Sword Saint and the Fire King helped you through those crises, of course, but coming through encounters with all of them unharmed is nearly impossible."

"…!"

I stared at her, my gaze turning cold.

I had a feeling I no longer needed to hear the answer to my question.

She knows about the Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

She didn't sound as though she merely knew their names from reports. She spoke as if she knew what kind of people they were and how powerful they were—as if she'd met them before.

At last, I could see who stood behind the name and identity of So Gyo.

…Dark Heaven.

Yeah. What else could it be?

Hadn't she said herself that one of the main reasons she stayed in the imperial palace was its vast intelligence network? She wasn't a loyal servant of the Emperor. She had another purpose.

She meant to get the imperial palace—or rather, the Emperor—in her grip and pull the strings.

The scattered pieces of the puzzle fell into place.

The Fourth Prince's sudden rebellion. The deaths of the late Emperor and the direct imperial family, and everything that had happened since.

But in the end, it had only been a partial success.

The Emperor had been replaced overnight, and countless people had gone to their deaths on the execution grounds. Even so, they'd failed to root out all opposition and take control of the entire Great Nation.

Then could it be…

Just as the last pieces were about to fall into place, So Gyo broke her silence.

"Let me ask you one thing. Why go this far?"

"Why?"

"Why fight me when your body's in such poor shape? You're even prepared to die taking me down."

I was quiet for a moment. Not because I needed to think about my answer, but because it was so obvious to me.

"Because fewer of my people will die if I do."

"What?"

"Even if we both die here, that's better than letting a bitch like you live."

"What if I said I had no intention of harming you?"

“That’s obviously bullshit, but sure.”

“Why?”

“Because a viper like you only does more harm the longer she lives.”

How many people had died already?

Every time Dark Heaven made a move, hundreds died. Then thousands. Eventually, tens of thousands vanished as lonely ghosts.

If my life was enough to put an end to that, I’d count myself lucky. Of course, the best outcome would be for me to live and So Gyo to die…

“But I don’t care either way. I won’t feel right until I’ve pulled out those damn fangs and stripped your skin off.”

This time, So Gyo fell silent. She kept her lips pressed together for a long while before tossing out a single remark.

“You’re even crazier than I thought.”

“What the hell are you talking about, you crazy bitch?”

“And I think I understand a little why Prince Shangshan, that child, looks up to you so much. Yes. I really do.”

“Are you threatening me because you’ve got a kid hostage?”

“Who knows?”

“What do you mean, ‘who knows’? Fuck. You’ve just given me one more reason to kill you, whatever it takes.”

“I like the enthusiasm. But things don’t always go the way you want.”

So Gyo shook her head slightly.

“To have reached this realm at your age… Your talent and what you’ve achieved are so remarkable they seem like a trick of heaven. No one could deny that. But…”

She went on slowly.

“Everything has its time. Being born with heavenly patterns won’t let you escape death.”

Swish.

I heard a faint sound against her collar.

The belt around So Gyo’s slender waist unfurled—no, it was a flexible sword. Filled with powerful internal energy, its blade pointed straight at me.

Beyond it, her eyes were cold.

“Shall we put it to the test? See whether heaven saves you or leaves you to die here?”

Whoooom.

A low, clear sword hum rang out.

Fwoosh.

Then I felt it unmistakably: an enormous, terrifying aura spreading from So Gyo, one I hadn’t sensed until now.

It closed around my whole body, pressing down on every part of me.

I drew in a breath without meaning to. The air had grown heavy in an instant, choking me. Every hair on my body stood on end, and cold sweat beaded on my skin.

But—

“Fuck off.”

I spat the words through my teeth and pushed against the invisible chains of internal energy. They bound my arms and legs tight, but I withstood them and moved toward So Gyo.

Crack. Thud.

One step.

Just one, and the solid bluestone beneath my foot shattered. The layers of earth below it caved in.

Was I that heavy? Had this place grown so decrepit after being abandoned for so long?

Neither.

I’d taken that step under the full pressure of internal energy weighing a thousand geun—ten thousand geun.[3359] And I’d withstood it not by countering her internal energy with my own, but with physical strength that had long since surpassed human limits.

Crunch. Craaack.

I put more force into my next step, trampling soil and flowers underfoot. Beneath them, I felt the bluestone fragments break again into dozens, then hundreds of pieces.

The closer I got, the stronger the pressure grew.

But…

I can take it.

A well-honed blade was a fine weapon on its own. So was the body I’d built by surviving countless brushes with death.

Strength. Stamina. Agility.

I excelled in all three. I’d surpassed my limits.

One of the main reasons I’d survived against enemies a level—or even two levels—above me was this body, which could wield superhuman strength without internal energy.

It could tear steel apart with bare hands, run for two days and nights without collapsing, and surge forward like the wind with a single push off the ground.

[3359] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand to ten thousand geun is about 600–6,000 kg (1,320–13,200 lb).

So even if several jiazi[3360] of internal energy closed around me, I could withstand it.

No. I could break it.

“Hah!”

With a short shout, I threw both arms out with all my strength.

Boom!

With so much power and speed behind it, the compressed air burst apart. I felt the internal energy that had surrounded and pressed down on me from every direction scatter.

Now!

My heavy body suddenly felt as light as a dandelion seed. I seized the opening and launched myself toward the one person staring at me with eyes now wide open.

So Gyo.

Fwoosh—boom!

Flamefire Path.

One step was all it took.

Scorching Yang Qi surged up from deep within my dantian and exploded from my foot. I crossed the five jang[3361] between us in an instant, blazing heat trailing behind me, and drove my fist forward like a cannon shot.

BANG!

The world shook.

Beyond the surging blue-white flames, a slender figure flew backward at tremendous speed to a roar that seemed to split the sky. Then she turned smoothly in midair.

Tap.

Her toes touched the blossom of a nameless flower, opened wide beneath the year’s strongest sunlight.

So Gyo landed on that single flower as lightly as a passing breeze. I almost gasped.

Ah.

Elusive, yet graceful.

Her movement technique was extraordinary. For an instant, I forgot she was my enemy. I even forgot I ought to press the attack while I had the chance.

So Gyo’s eyes flashed with something I couldn’t read.

“I couldn’t feel any internal energy from you at all… How did you do that?”

I wanted to ask her the same thing.

[3360] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[3361] A jang is ten ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Five jang is about 15.15 m (49.7 ft).

How had she blocked the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist I'd thrown with all my strength so easily? How had she met that blinding speed and force head-on without even looking strained?

You damn bitch. Have some conscience and at least pretend you're struggling.

I grumbled to myself and gave a wry smile.

Why was I laughing now? I didn't know. Maybe I really had gone crazy. Or maybe it was because I'd prepared myself to die before this fight began.

Yeah. That was it.

I'd been prepared for a long time.

"You die, I live."

Laughing like a man half out of his mind, I took a step forward.

My condition?

Of course I wasn't fine.

After unleashing so much power at once, my dantian was already lurching like an overworked engine. My internal energy no longer moved as freely as my hands and feet.

But this wasn't a sport played in a ring. There was no referee to stop the match, no second to throw in the towel for a fighter in danger.

That was what a life-and-death duel meant. I'd known it all along.

I'd already made my choice.

My body might be failing, but my resolve didn't waver.

Holding fast to that single thought, I charged So Gyo again.

Fwoosh!

The world slowed. The scenery around me shifted.

And at the moment I surrendered my whole body to the heat, the wind, and the fighting spirit bubbling like lava—

Screeeech!

With a violent whistle, a streak of light hurtled toward me like lightning.

Chapter 888

It all began and ended in the blink of an eye.

Whoosh!

A streak of light came hurtling in faster than the sound of it tearing through the air. And then…

KABOOM!

A deafening blast. A tremendous shock wave shoved my whole body backward.

“Hngh!”

Crack. I swallowed a breath and dug my feet in. The ground flipped up beneath them.

The gale whipped up by the impact sent pond water surging high into the air and swept through the rare flowers and plants covering the grounds.

Whooosh.

Anyone watching might have been overwhelmed for a moment and gasped in awe.

Countless petals swirling on the wind really were a spectacular sight.

But even the most carefree, clueless person would have groaned instead if they’d seen what had caused it.

Just like I was doing now.

“This is…”

My voice trailed off as I stared at *it*.

Amid the rain of pond water and petals, it stood embedded deep in the ground, radiating a chilling sharpness. I knew that weapon’s shape well.

“A crescent blade?”

The words slipped out before I could stop them. Then a low, resonant voice pierced my ear.

“Calling it just a crescent blade is a bit of an insult.”

I turned toward the voice. There was the face I’d half expected—and had very much hoped not to see here.

Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

I calmly addressed the man people called the Blood Envoy in fear.

“Then what is it?”

“Golden Dragon. That’s its name. It’s been my trusted weapon for over thirty years.”

“Golden Dragon, Goldie—doesn’t really matter to me either way. Still, I’m surprised.”

“Surprised by what?”

"Nothing. It just seems like if it's your trusted weapon, Blood Dragon would suit it better than Golden Dragon."

Baek Yeon had been approaching without hesitation, but at my pointed question, he stopped.

"Seems you've heard a few things about me."

"Plenty. Sounds like Goldie had quite a feast about ten years ago. You killed a lot of people with it."

"It's Golden Dragon, not Goldie. And it was necessary."

"Sure. I'm sure it was necessary."

I glanced between So Gyo and Baek Yeon, speaking sarcastically.

"For reasons the rest of us haven't been told."

"Perhaps. I won't bother defending myself, but even if only half of what you know or suspect is true, shouldn't you be more careful about what you say and do?"

"Careful about what I say and do?"

I let out a hollow laugh.

"In a fucked-up situation like this, I'd cuss out the Emperor himself—or his grandpa. Don't you think?"

I forced up the corners of my mouth, but I couldn't do anything about the tightness in my chest.

I'd already been preparing to face So Gyo alone, ready to fight to the death. And now Baek Yeon had shown up, too.

I didn't expect him to get here this fast. Was killing me already part of the plan?

Even calling this the worst possible situation didn't do it justice. Heavy-hearted, I stepped forward and gripped the crescent blade a few paces away.

Shing.

It slid free, cutting through solid ground as easily as a knife through tofu. The blade gleamed silver, so clear it was almost transparent.

It felt strange in my hand because it belonged to someone else. Yet the sharpness was familiar, and the anger that had briefly settled in me surged back up.

"Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. Guess the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard gets a hell of a weapon. I'm borrowing Goldie."

Baek Yeon stroked his chin beard.

"That's a troubling offer."

Why?

"Because you'll try to cut her and me down with it."

"Then you shouldn't have thrown it over."

"I was in a hurry. What else could I do?"

Baek Yeon shrugged.

"It has a deeper meaning to me, too. The late Emperor personally bestowed it on me the day I was appointed Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard."

"Then all the more reason I don't care. The late Emperor would rather I used it anyway. If I said I was going to beat the traitorous bastards with it, he'd jump out of that pond and throw me Silverie, too."

"…!"

"And this isn't an offer. I'm telling you."

At that moment, I saw it.

I saw Baek Yeon's thick eyebrows twitch, if only for a moment.

A brief silence fell. Then he spoke, his voice low and subdued.

"Must you really make such a fuss?"

"Will it end with just a fuss?"

I quietly went over the plan I'd revised while we talked.

If I fight them here, I'll die for nothing. I need to draw as many eyes here as I can.

What would happen if I had to fight two masters who were both above me?

I didn't need to think hard about it. I'd lose. No question.

I do have One Annihilation as a last resort, but I can't even be sure that would work.

One Annihilation wasn't invincible, and my body was already at its limit.

Even with the recovery I got from Level Ups, I'd ended up like this. What would happen now, without the System?

It really would be my last move.

The problem was, even if I burned my life away to use it, I might not take a single person with me. It could turn into a suicide mission that got me killed after missing my target.

That's a little too far over the line.

I had no interest in becoming some dumbass who missed, exhausted himself, and died—or an SSS-rank suicide Hunter.

Now that things had come to this, I had no choice but to turn it into an all-out battle.

They had their own plans, and so did the anti-Emperor faction led by Ma Sanbao. But none of that mattered to me now.

No—the truth was, I didn't have the luxury of thinking about their plans with those two monsters in front of me.

Since we're here, I'll pull every damn stunt I can.

Luckily, I had allies inside the imperial palace.

I didn't know the details, but there were Murim assassins Ma Sanbao had brought in. And above all, the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was there.

Not to mention the people already plotting against the Emperor.

We had a decent chance of winning that fight.

Now that I'd worked it out, there was no point hesitating. I angled the crescent blade in my hand, ready to get out of here at once.

Whooom.

They said a weapon that spent a long time with one owner could take on a soul of its own. As the blade trembled, seeming to reject its unfamiliar wielder and unfamiliar qi, I remembered something Jang Taebo had once said. The former Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild was now a retainer of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

But…

Settle down.

Fwoosh.

Its brief resistance vanished as blue-white flames flared up, and I launched myself forward with all my strength.

Or I would have.

Just as the flames of Flamefire Path were about to burst from my feet, So Gyo spoke.

"You'd better stop before you regret it."

"What?"

"Prince Shangshan. Zhu Bao."

"…!"

Just five syllables, but they were enough to stop me in my tracks.

In all the confusion, I'd overlooked one thing.

Right.

They still had that child.

As long as Prince Shangshan was in Qianqing Palace, the Emperor held his life in his hands.

Qianqing Palace was a demon-slaying battleground. Just from what I'd seen with my own eyes, there were no fewer than four Supreme Peak masters there, including the Emperor.

It wouldn't matter if it were me or the Fire King. Even if the Martial God himself returned, he couldn't do anything about the blade at the young prince's throat.

"Choose which path to take. And think about what awaits you at the end of it."

Her tone was calm. The air around us was cold, and I had to force my voice through clenched teeth.

"What the hell are you trying to get out of this?"

"You don't need to know. What matters is that you'll survive here today."

Survive? Me?

The lackeys of Dark Heaven would just let me go, now that they had leverage over me?

I could only blink at her unexpected words. Then So Gyo added,

“And I hope you do.”

“You do?”

“Yes.”

“…Why?”

“Because there’s still a reason to keep you alive. That’s my mission, too.”

My eyes widened before I knew it.

I’d heard something like that only a few months ago.

From none other than the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

That was why I couldn’t help seeing the Southern Heaven Demon Empress as she’d been then, overlaid with the So Gyo standing before me now.

The Southern Heaven Demon Empress had held back from killing me as much as she could, even right up until she was about to turn into a monster. Just like So Gyo is now.

If so, the meaning could only be one thing.

Just like the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, So Gyo—or rather, the Lord of Heaven—still wanted me.

Not my cold corpse, my soul already gone.

Me.

Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

Why?

None of it made any sense. I’d thwarted Dark Heaven’s plans at every turn, even cutting off two of their limbs in the process: the Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress.

The Lord of Heaven had begun a war with the Murim of the Central Plains. As far as he was concerned, I was one of the obstacles he ought to chew to pieces.

So why?

A memory flashed through my mind.

The underground prison beneath the Sichuan Tang Clan. The whispers of that deep darkness I’d briefly encountered when it borrowed the body of the Western Heaven Demon Lord, who had unmistakably died.

How interesting. How very interesting.

And the eerie laughter that had seeped through that darkness.

We’ll meet again.

“…!”

Had it started then?

Had those words been the beginning?

Crack.

Without my noticing, I'd clenched my fist so tight it had gone white, the veins standing out across it. Every hair on my body stood on end as I tried to steady myself. So Gyo watched me calmly.

"So, what's your answer?"

I closed my eyes, forgetting for a moment that I had an enemy right in front of me.

Then, the next instant—

Swish.

I reversed my grip on the crescent blade and hurled it like a beam of light.

Whoosh! Kaboom!

The blade tore through the air. A thunderous boom followed.

Baek Yeon recovered his weapon from where it had buried itself deep in the ground one step ahead of him and clicked his tongue.

"You have quite a dramatic way of returning it."

If this had happened just fifteen minutes ago, I'd have fired back with a sarcastic quip. But not now.

I gritted my teeth and spoke to the two of them.

"Don't… touch Prince Shangshan."

"Rest assured. Nothing like what you're worried about will happen."

I had no way of knowing whether that answer was true or false.

All I could do was look for another way.

Still, I learned one thing. As long as the Lord of Heaven's orders stand, they can't move against me lightly.

Suppressing the killing intent I felt toward So Gyo and Baek Yeon, I started walking. To borrow a saying from Murim, from this moment on, fifteen minutes would feel like three autumns.

The grand banquet would soon be held in the imperial palace.

That celebration would become the battlefield where our fates were decided.

The Hongmen Banquet[3362]*. So who's Xiang Yu, and who's Liu Bang?*

I turned and walked away without hesitation. Before I'd completely disappeared from their sight, with my back to them, So Gyo's voice suddenly reached me.

"Why did you give up fighting, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung? Do you want Prince Shangshan to become Emperor, too?"

A laugh escaped me.

The question hardly deserved an answer.

Still, I kept walking without turning around.

"Yeah. Since we're going this far, of course I want him to become Emperor. But that's not the only reason."

[3362] The Hongmen Banquet was a historical feast at which Xiang Yu considered killing his rival Liu Bang. The name evokes a banquet that may be a deadly trap.

“Then what is?”
“He’s a kid.”
I kept going, with no idea where I was headed, and muttered,
“He’s still a kid, you crazy bastards.”

Chapter 889

Those who were going to leave left. Those who were going to stay stayed.

So Gyo watched Jin Taekyung until he vanished in the distance, turning over the faint words the wind had carried to her moments ago.

He's still a kid, you crazy bastards.

She wondered what expression Jin Taekyung had worn then, and how much of the anger and bitterness in his departing figure had been genuine.

There was no way for her to know.

You can plumb ten fathoms of water, but never one fathom of a person's heart.

As So Gyo repeated the saying to herself, Baek Yeon spoke.

"How much of this did you intend?"

"Intend?"

"Did you intend for Jin Taekyung to come here?"

So Gyo shook her head slightly.

"Not particularly. What happened just now was a coincidence."

"A coincidence. Then why did you ask His Majesty to let him move about freely?"

"I needed to watch him more closely. You already know some of the reasons I've been staying in the imperial palace, don't you?"

"Could it be…?"

Baek Yeon's eyes widened. So Gyo answered in an even voice.

"I can't be certain yet…but I think he's the one. The person I've been looking for. The person that person foretold."

The beautiful woman in her thirties spoke to the graying veteran without the slightest formality, but Baek Yeon paid it no mind.

The woman calling herself So Gyo had the standing and the strength to speak that way. Besides, her answer was more astonishing than he'd expected.

"So that's why you had him stay in the imperial palace?"

"I had to see for myself whether the rumors about the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung, were true. Whether he really was the one that person spoke of. And…"

So Gyo turned her head. Her gaze swept over the place where someone had been moments ago, though that person was already gone. For an instant, her eyes gleamed sharply.

"What kind of person he is."

The chance encounter had turned out well. Perhaps not for Jin Taekyung, who had left in anger, but So Gyo had seen enough to sort out her thoughts and gain a measure of certainty.

The Huashan Divine Dragon, Cheongpung. The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

She placed the names of the two rising martial artists she'd been watching on the scales in her mind. Unlike when she'd first learned of them, the scales now tipped toward one.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

As she'd told Baek Yeon, it was too soon to be certain. But given Jin Taekyung's past actions and what she'd seen and sensed herself, there was a good chance he was the person she sought.

That must be why that person entrusted this task to me.

So Gyo slowly crossed the flower garden.

Their brief clash had left it looking as though a storm had swept through. At its center, something that had been hidden beneath the flowers and grass poked up through the dirt.

"It's been a long time."

How deep had it been buried? How long had it lain there?

So Gyo greeted the familiar object as if speaking to herself, then reached out.

Whoooom—thunk!

An enormous, unseen surge of qi shook the air. Two objects buried deep in the ground shot up into So Gyo's hands.

They were identical in length and width, as if measured with a ruler. Each curved gently toward its tip, much like a saber.

So Gyo hung one at each hip, then spoke to Baek Yeon, who was watching her.

"It'll be a fierce battle. Maybe fiercer than the one over a decade ago."

Baek Yeon nodded.

"I'm prepared."

"Enough to stake your life on it?"

"Do you know something?"

His expression remained calm as he went on.

"I've always staked my life on getting what I wanted. That's how I made it this far."

"I hope you do the same this time."

"I must. I will."

Baek Yeon's eyes grew as grave as his voice.

"May I ask you one thing?"

So Gyo nodded.

"Anything, if it's something I can answer."

"Why are you leaving the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung, alone?"

"Why?"

“That’s right.”

“You must have guessed already.”

“Of course I have. But before we wipe them all out in one place, we should go after Jin Taekyung right now—”

“Impossible.”

So Gyo cut him off firmly.

“There’s still more I need to confirm. Until then, it’s better to let things proceed as they are.”

“What if he becomes an obstacle to the great undertaking?”

“An obstacle? How?”

“As you know, Jin Taekyung’s master is the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. And, as it happens, he vanished without a trace after reaching the Imperial Capital. The other Murim martial artists following Jin Taekyung won’t make much difference, but…if they draw the Fire King in as well, things could become complicated.”

Baek Yeon was genuinely worried.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

The government and Murim might be meant to stay out of each other’s affairs, but after more than a hundred years, there was no one in the land who hadn’t heard of him.

And Baek Yeon, who had led the Embroidered Uniform Guard since the late Emperor’s reign, knew better than most which of the countless rumors about the Fire King were true.

A hero born of the Great Faction War. A demon awakened by the Demonic Cult.

A man whose martial prowess towered above even those powerful enough to be called kings.

He could not reach someone born in a human body and called a god, but he stood shoulder to shoulder with the Three Stars. If he took the other side, they would have to be prepared for tremendous losses.

Even with So Gyo, Baek Yeon himself, the Emperor, and several other Supreme Peak masters on their side.

“Their forces are already formidable. And that’s only what we’ve managed to learn so far. If the Fire King joins them after Jin Taekyung…”

“The Fire King? That wouldn’t be bad.”

For a moment, Baek Yeon doubted his ears.

Then So Gyo continued, a faint smile on her lips, and he realized she meant it.

“No. That might be even better.”

“…!”

Leaving Baek Yeon frozen like a statue, unable to understand her at all, So Gyo turned away with a quiet laugh.

The words she hadn’t told him drifted through her mind.

Wait. You’ll know soon enough.

Baek Yeon thought he knew everything, but he was wrong.

The story So Gyo had kept from him was something only she and the Emperor knew. Secrets were better off unknown.

At least until the banquet both allies and enemies were so eagerly awaiting.

“Only three days left until then.”

So Gyo looked up at the sky, now dark, and murmured. Cold raindrops began to fall, as if confirming her sense that the calm before the storm was already upon them.

Shaaah.

Heavy rain hammered everything around us.

It swallowed even the shouts of palace attendants running here and there in woven bamboo hats and rain cloaks.

I’d spent a good while in Murim, but I’d never seen a downpour like this. The unexpected rain and thunder were more than enough to obscure the watchers’ view.

“You’re really going?”

Hyuk Mujin’s face was tense.

“I have to.”

“What if they catch you…?”

“They won’t. Not in this situation. You were there and heard it too, so you know.”

“I know. I know it’s urgent. But still…”

“It’ll be all right if it’s Young Master Jin.”

Hong Jin spoke up, his voice subdued.

“Even if they spot him, there’s a good chance they’ll pretend they didn’t.”

“Huh? What do you mean?”

“If what Young Master Jin told us is true, they want to wipe us all out at once. They intend to uproot us in one fell swoop…and that leaves us no choice.”

I nodded silently.

Would So Gyo and Baek Yeon have let me go without thinking it through?

Even knowing full well I’d tell their enemies what had happened?

No way.

This was both a warning and a declaration: don’t try to avoid the all-or-nothing battle ahead. And we couldn’t refuse.

With Prince Shangshan in their grasp, there's no way out of it, no matter what we do.

Our enemies had engineered this situation because they were confident they'd win. But however thoroughly they'd prepared, whatever traps they'd set, we couldn't back down.

We have to fight. Right now, before we worry about winning or losing, we have to make a decision.

The stage was set. So were the actors.

Our enemies had built the stage intending to star in the show. But sometimes a supporting actor defies everyone's expectations and outshines the lead.

That was my job.

To change who took center stage—and how this story ended.

Fortunately, there was one important cameo in the imperial palace that our enemies didn't know about.

Old Master.

I stared out the window at the sheets of rain.

The downpour obscured my view, and the sky was already pitch-black. Below the pavilion, members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard stood watch in shifts.

There were about twenty of them, every one a Peak master.

But even Supreme Peak masters couldn't predict a sudden lightning strike.

Flash! Kaboom!

Now.

At the instant white light flashed and a thunderous boom rang out, I pushed off the railing and sprang into the air.

Whoosh!

The Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step, a signature martial art created by the greatest assassin of all time, unfolded beneath my feet.

I hadn't been taught it formally; I'd only worked a little of it into my movements. But that was enough to slip past the watchers in the brief confusion.

Tap. Swish!

I landed on the roof of a pavilion whose name I didn't know, one said to house the palace attendants, and shot forward—quietly but swiftly.

The layout of the imperial palace was already etched deep in my mind. I didn't hesitate.

From here, along the east-west axis.

The grounds were vast, with pavilions scattered across them.

My black clothes blended into the darkness, and the guards posted throughout the grounds never caught sight of me.

"Damn, it's really coming down."

“The grand banquet’s right around the corner, and now the weather’s like this…”

The Imperial Guards grumbled as they looked up at the sky from beneath the eaves. They had no idea an uninvited guest had just passed two steps behind them and entered the Outer Palace.

But not everything went smoothly.

“What are you doing here?”

“Y-Yes, sir!”

“If I remember the regulations correctly, your assigned post isn’t beneath the eaves.”

The Imperial Guards weren’t the only ones startled by that voice, hard as rock. I was about to move on when I saw the familiar face that had suddenly appeared and swallowed a groan.

Fuck, what’s that bastard doing here?

Jeong Hogun.

A high-ranking Thousand Captain in the Embroidered Uniform Guard, he was walking toward the Imperial Guards.

And at the same time, he was heading toward me, concealed not far away in the darkness.

Chapter 890

Clank. Clank.

Heavy footsteps drew closer, accompanied by the metallic clatter of heavy armor.

Hidden in the darkness just thirty feet away, I felt my heart seize up at Jeong Hogun's sudden appearance.

What the hell are you doing here…?

I didn't know why a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, which was responsible for the Inner Palace, had wandered all the way out here. But one thing was certain: at this distance, one clumsy move could give me away to Commander Jeong.

Damn it. If I'd known this would happen, I should've learned the concealment technique properly.

Regret washed over me, but it was far, far too late for that.

I'd struggled tooth and nail to survive in Murim, and that was how I'd met Jeok Cheongang. After inheriting the Fire Gate Clan's legacy, a good old-fashioned brawl had become both my only major and my general-education requirement.

What kind of sect was the Fire Gate Clan?

Just look at the records of its past Sect Leaders. Every last one of them was a no-holds-barred tough guy. The kind of lunatic who looked like he'd take a shit standing up.

For three hundred years, this hipster sect with a pedigree had picked fights with the orthodox, unorthodox, and demonic paths alike. To the Fire Gate Clan, the concealment technique was practically a symbol of weakness.

One of its Sect Leaders, said to have been the greatest master in the world some two hundred years ago, had even left behind this record:

> Want to learn the concealment technique?
> Then you're a homosexual.

Behold the audacity of treating one of Murim's essential survival skills as a martial art for fags.

If he'd said that in the twenty-first century, a mob would've beaten him with rainbow-colored clubs. But for better or worse, this was Murim, a world steeped in barbarism, and the Fire Gate Clan's lineage had carried on.

The problem was that, thanks to those fine ancestors and their policies, I was about to get screwed.

Seriously, shit. In three hundred years, couldn't one Sect Leader have learned the concealment technique?

My mouth went dry. Maybe it was nerves, but I was starting to need to piss.

Jeong Hogun had come within ten feet of me. His face was hard as he questioned the Imperial Guards who'd neglected their post.

"Answer me. Why did you leave your assigned post?"

"S-Sorry, sir. The rain was so heavy, we started shivering…"

"Would you say the same thing if traitors slipped into the imperial palace undetected?"

"Of course not. We're truly sorry, but…"

"Enough excuses. Who is your immediate superior?"

"W-Well, that is…"

"You don't want to say? No, judging by how you've neglected your duty, perhaps you don't want to serve in the Imperial Guard at all."

"N-No, sir!"

"Then is this inside or outside?"

"…?"

"…?"

What was this? It reminded me of the Hunter Training Center.

Is this bastard a System user…?

I kept my presence hidden as best I could and watched, entertaining that reasonable suspicion about Jeong Hogun. Then he said something that made me doubt my ears.

"As of today, you are no longer members of the Imperial Guard. Go to your superior immediately, report what happened here, and turn in your badges, uniforms, weapons, and other equipment. I'll guard this post myself until your replacements arrive."

"…!"

"…!"

It was a bolt from the blue.

For the guards who'd only taken shelter from the rain beneath the eaves—and for me, waiting desperately for Jeong Hogun to leave.

"G-General!"

"Military law is strict. This is an order from me as a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard."

No. Don't listen to him.

You're civilians now anyway. Just punch him.

I fervently cheered on the middle-aged reservists—I mean, the Imperial Guard soldiers—but the two men who'd just been sent through the process of discharge still had a shred of reason left.

In the military, when they tell you to jump, you ask how high. And the Embroidered Uniform Guard was the place that could even cut off the heads of the highest officials—the sort who could make a flying bird drop from the sky.

Only two kinds of people could tell Jeong Hogun to go to hell right now:

Lunatics. Or people hoping to join the Fire Gate Clan.

Unfortunately, the two men in front of him were neither. They were perfectly normal.

“We’ll… obey your order.”

Their voices weak, they pulled their rain hats low and trudged away.

Or they tried to.

Just as Jeong Hogun had a moment ago, someone entirely unexpected appeared.

“How strange. Since when could the Embroidered Uniform Guard dismiss Imperial Guards on a whim?”

Swish.

The hem of a long robe brushed a puddle. A figure emerged through the endless rain. Jeong Hogun was silent for a moment before speaking.

“Eunuch Ma, what brings you here?”

“Nothing in particular. I was taking care of something outside and am on my way back. But…”

Ma Sanbao—the East Depot’s second-in-command and its de facto leader—smiled faintly.

“Could I have an answer to my question, Commander Jeong?”

“…I was only enforcing military law.”

“Of course you were. I know what a fine and capable man you are. But…”

At that moment, Ma Sanbao’s voice, which had always seemed to hover somewhere between a man’s and a woman’s, dropped low.

“Follow procedure. Follow procedure.”

“That’s…”

“The Imperial Guard may be under the Embroidered Uniform Guard, but there’s still a process to follow, isn’t there? The authority to impose a final punishment clearly belongs to their superior. That’s the military law you mentioned.”

“…!”

“That’s all I have to say. Is there anything else?”

Jeong Hogun stared at Ma Sanbao in silence, then spoke.

“No.”

“Good. Since we’ve run into each other, why don’t we walk together for a while?”

“Walk together?”

“Yes. It’s been quite some time, and I’m glad to see you. Besides, there’s something important I’d like to discuss. You’re heading back to the Inner Palace anyway, aren’t you?”

Jeong Hogun probably meant to answer, “No,” or “Now isn’t a good time.”

His expression didn’t change, but for an instant I could see his wariness and reluctance in his profile.

Ma Sanbao was half a beat faster.

“Oh, you don’t mind? Good. I knew you’d say that.”

The East Depot’s authority had been curtailed after the rebellion more than a decade ago, while the Embroidered Uniform Guard had risen to prominence. Even so, Ma Sanbao had long since become the East Depot’s de facto leader in place of the bedridden Cang Gong.

Before Jeong Hogun could get a word in, Ma Sanbao seized the initiative with an easy smile and patted him on the shoulder.

“Come along. There’s plenty to tell the Embroidered Uniform Guard—and plenty I need to hear.”

Ma Sanbao was both a Supreme Peak master and a skilled politician. For Jeong Hogun, a martial artist through and through, he was the worst possible opponent.

Having lost control of the conversation in an instant, Jeong Hogun could only leave with him, his face rigid as a rock. He did remember to leave a stern warning for the two Imperial Guards who’d escaped their surprise firing.

“As soon as your shift ends, report what happened here to your superior. Understood?”

“Y-Yes, sir.”

“Understood!”

Of course they’d say yes now.

The guards snapped to attention and gave a hearty salute. Jeong Hogun turned away, and I was breathing an inward sigh of relief when a Sound Transmission reached my ear.

—I don’t know exactly why you’ve come all the way here, but there are many eyes watching. Be careful and use your wits. I’ll send word to you myself later.

“…!”

I whipped my head around. Ma Sanbao was looking my way and winking.

He knew. From the beginning.

I was a little startled, but it made sense when I thought about it.

Ma Sanbao was a master of the concealment technique who’d reached the Supreme Peak realm. He might not be as skilled as the Slaughter Saint, hailed as the greatest assassin of all time, but he was more than capable of spotting my amateurish attempt.

Did he expect me and come looking? Or was it just a coincidence?

I had no idea.

I didn't know why he'd appeared here, or how he'd brought the assassins of Murim into this.

What mattered right now was that the Imperial Guards still nearby weren't skilled enough to detect me.

Swish.

I moved like a shadow through the darkness, helped by the unrelenting rain and crashing thunder.

After leaping over several pavilions and walls, I picked up a timely hint from a conversation between some other Imperial Guard soldiers.

"Have you seen 'that guy'?"

"Who? Oh, I think I know who you mean. He's a monster."

"I thought he was just big, but damn, can he eat. Especially five-spice pork. It hasn't even been half a shichen[3363], and he's already put away more than twenty plates. The cooks are up in arms."

"Good grief. I'd heard about him, but that much?"

"He's a lunatic, I'm telling you. At this rate, they say he'll eat every pig in Zhejiang Province with that mouth of his within a month. He looks like he's got a pigsty in his stomach."

"Impressive. But wouldn't it be better to kick him out?"

"The imperial family has its reputation to consider. They can't treat people brought here for the grand banquet poorly just because they eat a little pork. Orders have already been given to provide them with whatever they need for lodging and meals."

"Good grief…"

They hadn't even said his name. Just *that guy*.

Why was I embarrassed on his behalf?

Taishan, you bastard…

I looked to the heavens and sighed. Then I noticed a group hurrying somewhere.

There were a dozen or so of them, each carrying a large plate.

And then there was the rich smell of five-spice pork, strong enough to clear the nose of someone with sinusitis.

"…!"

I'd known my companions were staying somewhere in the Outer Palace, but not where their rooms were. I hadn't expected to find them this way.

Is this for real?

[3363] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

I followed the group like Hansel and Gretel, quiet enough that no one noticed me.

All the while, a middle-aged man who looked like a cook fired off curses in a steady stream.

“Please, just stop fucking eating. If you’re human, please…”

That was when I saw it.

The large kitchen knife in his other hand was trembling.

“Food’s here.”

Creak—BANG!

The door to the pavilion flew open with a rough shove, and the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was surprised twice.

First, the middle-aged cook, who clearly hadn’t learned martial arts, was giving off genuine killing intent.

Second, behind the exhausted cook and the others carrying stacks of food, a familiar face was peeking out of the darkness.

“Y-You…!”

“What is it?”

“N-Nothing.”

“If it’s nothing, take some of this food. My arms are about to break.”

The cook’s reply was sharp. He had the palace attendants set down the plates, then left—after warning them that if they ordered five-spice pork one more time today, he’d poison it.

No sooner were they gone than a breeze blew open the door they’d just shut.

At least, that was how it would have looked to anyone else.

“What are you waiting for? Get in here.”

At the Fire King’s abrupt command, a young man appeared from the darkness and grinned.

“I’m here.”

Chapter 891

It had only been a few days—not long enough to call this a reunion—but it was still good to see everyone again.

And “a few days” was only on paper. It had felt more like a few months.

So much had happened.

Still, how should I put it? Seeing familiar faces made this strange place feel, for a moment, like home. I liked that.

I smiled and waved at the group that had rushed over to me.

“Wow, it feels like ages since I’ve seen you all. How’ve you been?”

The reactions came at once.

Jeok Cheongang snorted, pretending it was nothing. Why was I making such a fuss when he’d seen me just a few shichen[3364] ago? Sama Pyo and Song Ilseom silently nodded. Ju Hwaran, who’d frozen like a statue when I appeared, suddenly flew down the stairs like a streak of light. Her voice unsteady, she said,

“B-Benefactor. No, Pavilion Master. Is there anywhere you *aren’t* hurt?”

“Huh?”

“N-No, that came out wrong. What I mean is…”

“You’re asking if I’m hurt anywhere?”

“Ah. Yes!”

The Divine Physician had come closer without my noticing. He chuckled warmly.

“I’m glad you don’t seem to have suffered too much. Young Lady Ju here can finally breathe a little easier, too.”

Ju Hwaran flinched.

“Me?”

“Is that not so? You seemed more worried than I was, and I’m the physician.”

“Th-That’s… As a member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion, isn’t it only natural that I’d worry about the Pavilion Master’s safety?”

“Ah, of course it is. Quite right.”

The Divine Physician nodded like a grandfather agreeing with his granddaughter, then winked at me.

“So she says.”

“Uh…”

What on earth was I supposed to say to that?

I felt strangely awkward and was scrambling for an answer when a shadow fell over my head. Something damp touched my scalp.

Plop. Plop.

[3364] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

For an instant, I thought rain was leaking through the ceiling. Then I heard the rough breathing behind me and felt the sticky saliva.

Oh. You bastard.

I didn't need to look to know who it was. I glanced up, and there he was, drooling exactly as I'd expected.

"Taishan is very very happy and glad to see the Pavilion Master again."

Was this lunatic for real? Listen to how fast he was talking.

"Pavilion Master doing well Taishan doing well Taishan ate five-spice pork and ate five-spice pork and ate five-spice pork."

So all he'd done was stuff his face.

Even now, he wasn't looking at me. He was staring at the mountain of plates piled in one corner.

"Taishan has finished preparing everything to help the Pavilion Master just give the order."

"…"

He was clearly ready to eat five-spice pork, so I gave the order in a voice drained of all hope.

"Fine. Eat it before it gets cold."

"Taishan will obey the Pavilion Master's command!"

With an answer more enthusiastic than ever, Taishan hurled his massive body forward and began slaughtering the five-spice pork.

I watched the horrific scene with glazed eyes, then remembered someone I'd forgotten.

"Wait. Where's Elder Namho?"

"I'm here."

Namho came shuffling down the stairs, one hand on his lower back, his face gloomy.

"I was resting for a moment. Maybe it's because I'm old, but my body's not what it used to be."

"What happened? Did you hurt yourself?"

"I went to the privy, and then…"

"Oh no. Did you slip?"

"It's the imperial palace, so I suppose they keep even the privies well greased. I was hanging on to a ceiling beam when my strength gave out."

"A ceiling beam? Not the floor?"

As I stared at him in confusion, the Divine Physician whispered to me.

"I believe he hid in the privy to ambush Taishan."

"…"

"He'll be fine soon. He may be old, but he's in excellent shape."

This was a complete shitshow. Seriously.

I let out a deep sigh and looked around at the people gathered in a circle around me.

Some were normal, some weren't, but they'd all followed me into the imperial palace—a tiger's den—for my sake.

They knew how dangerous this mission was, and they'd risked their one and only lives. I couldn't hide anything from them or lie to them while we discussed what to do.

"I can't stay away for as long as I'd like, so I'll keep this quick."

I took a quiet, deep breath and began to speak.

Or tried to.

Chomp. Chomp. *Pah-ooh.*[3365]

"…"

Please, stop eating.

As soon as I finished pouring out everything that had happened over the past few days, a hushed silence settled over the pavilion.

It made sense.

They'd already learned about some of it through the East Depot, but there were things they were hearing for the first time here.

Jeok Cheongang was the first to break the silence.

"What a goddamn mess."

He muttered under his breath, his gaze darkening.

"Six Supreme Peak masters, and Embroidered Uniform Guards of that caliber… Is this what they mean when they call it a Great Nation?"

I corrected him with a heavy heart.

"That's only what I saw for myself. They could have other masters hidden away."

"Hah."

Murim and the government might look as though they were kept completely separate, but the truth was different.

A Great Nation meant a continent. The forces hunkered down in the imperial capital were so powerful that even Jeok Cheongang had to groan.

And there was an unexpected wild card among them.

"First, tell us more about that woman called So Gyo. Her appearance, her way of speaking. What weapon she uses and how she moves."

[3365] *Pah-ooh* renders a Korean comic sound associated with heavy breathing while eating.

Jeok Cheongang seemed more wary of So Gyo than anyone else. I told them everything I'd seen and felt, describing even her movements during our brief clash in detail.

Yet even Jeok Cheongang, who was among the three oldest in the martial world, and Namho, whose knowledge was second to none, couldn't offer a clear answer.

"Her manner of speaking doesn't give us much to go on. But I've never heard of a master with that appearance who uses a flexible sword."

"I agree with Senior Jeok. If she's serving Dark Heaven, she must be one of the demonic or heterodox martial artists. But even among the fiends the Hidden Shadow Pavilion identified during the Great Faction War, women of that caliber were very rare."

Namho turned to me, worry in his voice.

"Did you notice anything strange? We can't rule out the possibility that she was using a finely crafted human-skin mask or a disguise technique."

I thought back for a moment, then shook my head.

The deeper one's martial arts realm, the sharper one's eye became.

No matter how well made a human-skin mask was, it had its limits. And maintaining a disguise technique took a constant supply of internal energy. From what I'd seen, I hadn't felt the slightest trace of anything like that.

"No. At least, from what I felt, it didn't seem like she was using either of those methods."

"But there's still a chance—"

"Enough. If that boy says so, then that's how it is."

Jeok Cheongang had walked the same path I had, and gone farther down it. His understanding was beyond anything Namho, who hadn't learned martial arts, could match.

After cutting Namho off firmly, Jeok Cheongang slowly stroked his chin.

"She has a supreme footwork technique and has reached Returning to Simplicity. How old did you say she was?"

"Maybe thirty? She looked no older than her mid-thirties at most."

"To possess that kind of martial prowess at thirty[3366] is impossi—"

Jeok Cheongang met my eyes and trailed off.

"—not impossible, but about as close to it as you can get."

"Why are you looking at me like that while we're talking?"

"When did this old man do that?"

"Just now."

"Do you want to get your ass kicked?"

[3366] The source uses *irip*, a Confucian expression for the age of thirty, drawn from the saying "At thirty, I stood firm."

"No."

"Then shut up."

"Yes, sir."

So this was how Hyuk Mujin felt.

Sorry. I'll treat you better when we get back.

I kept quiet, chastened. Jeok Cheongang downed a cup of cold water in one go and clicked his tongue.

"Damn it. It's one of two things. Either the Lord of Heaven took a prodigy for the ages as his Disciple and raised her all this time, or she's an old monster who's gone beyond Returning to Simplicity and Returned to Youth."

"Personally, I think it's the latter. The Southern Heaven Demon Empress was the same."

"That's probably more likely. Even when the world was shaken by the Great Faction War, there were people living in seclusion in remote mountains and valleys. This old man was one of them. There's no guarantee that the woman called So Gyo wasn't, too."

It was a perfectly plausible explanation.

Nearly half a century had passed since the old sky of the Demonic Cult closed and a new one, Dark Heaven, opened.

Many of the people who'd emerged under Dark Heaven's command in the present day were old masters from a previous generation, the kind known as fiends. But key figures like the Blood Lord, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress were people the world hadn't known about at all.

So Gyo probably belongs in the same category.

But something mattered more than discovering So Gyo's identity.

Why had she let me go when she could have subdued me?

No matter how much I thought about it, I couldn't find an easy answer.

"I don't get it. Why did So Gyo go out of her way to make that choice?"

Ju Hwaran, who'd been listening without a word, suddenly spoke up.

"I haven't been able to understand it either. This may be rude to you, Pavilion Master, but… why let a fish that's already been caught in the net go free?"

"Perhaps they intend to catch us all at once at the grand banquet that's coming up."

Song Ilseom, seated beside her, answered. Ju Hwaran shook her head.

"If word gets out, that only makes things harder for them. Now that they've done this, won't we fight the decisive battle with everything we have?"

She was right.

It would've made sense if the people gathered here were the entirety of our side's forces. But the restoration army that had spent more than a decade preparing under Ma Sanbao's leadership was no joke either.

If they didn't have a chance of winning with their forces, they never would've dreamed of staging a coup in the first place.

So did the enemy know nothing about this?

Of course not.

The current Emperor had gradually reduced the East Depot's authority as soon as the rebellion succeeded. That was practically proof that he'd kept it in check because he'd been worried about a situation like this.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard is no weaker than the East Depot in either force or intelligence. They must have been keeping a close watch, too.

At least, that was the impression I'd gotten of the Emperor.

Thorough, calculating, and someone who would always uproot a future source of trouble.

A cold, ruthless ruler. The master of a continent, with the power to match.

It was hard to explain why someone like that had stood by and let all this happen.

Unless there was only one possibility.

He's certain. No matter what we try, no matter how desperately we fight, the outcome won't change.

You could trample weeds again and again, and they still wouldn't wither.

But pull out every root in one go, and the weeds would finally be gone.

Damn it.

The air around us grew heavy.

Chapter 892

I'd faced countless formidable enemies and fought more battles than I could count, but this was a first.

For me—and for everyone else.

"They're planning to raise the stakes even further… If that guess is right, they've got to be completely insane."

At Jeok Cheongang's mutter, Namho nodded.

"It's hard to believe, but for our enemies, that's the fastest shortcut to taking control of the entire Great Nation."

He was right.

Nothing settled things quite like a character-deletion match.[3367] Once a single battle with everything on the line was over, the winner would survive and the loser would disappear.

The problem was that we had no idea what lay behind our enemies' confidence.

Where the hell are they getting that confidence?

It was easy to call it a single decisive battle, but this wasn't just another life-and-death duel of the kind that happened all the time between martial artists.

It would be an enormous battle with the fate of the Great Nation at stake—and, without a doubt, a bloodbath that would paint the Imperial Capital red.

If we lose this battle, the restoration army will be wiped out in an instant, and Dark Heaven and the Emperor will take complete control of the Great Nation. But is that really all?

Namho had said it was the fastest shortcut for the enemy.

But a shortcut wasn't always the best choice. There was a reason people took the established road.

A main road was wide and straight. Even if it took a little longer, you could reach your destination easily and comfortably.

A shortcut, though, was narrow and complicated. The ground was uneven and unpaved, and sometimes you had to pass through shadowy alleys where danger—and foul smells—lurked.

And yet the enemy chose the shortcut. They even used me as bait to do it.

Even if it was all part of a larger plan, those choices seemed almost reckless.

They hadn't stopped me, even though I'd repeatedly gotten in Dark Heaven's way. They'd deliberately made a battle they absolutely had to win that much harder.

And I wasn't the only one thinking about it.

"Why?"

[3367] Korean gaming slang for a match in which the loser must delete their game character.

Jeok Cheongang rose and paced, muttering as if to himself.

"Even if they don't know this old man is in the imperial palace, they should have considered the possibility if they know what happened in Nanman."

Dark Heaven's intelligence network was vast. There was no way So Gyo or the Emperor hadn't heard what even Ma Sanbao knew.

They must have received the same information: Fire King Jeok Cheongang had intervened in the process of defeating the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, and had left Nanman with me.

And still, they'd let me go.

As if they hadn't even considered the existence of a predator called the Fire King. As if that predator joining the battle wouldn't make the slightest difference to the outcome.

This… really is strange.

No, more than strange. Suspicious.

I could understand why they might discount me. I was already in rough shape, and they might have been acting on some kind of instruction from the Lord of Heaven.

But Jeok Cheongang?

He'd already stood at the top of the Ten Kings during the Great Faction War. They said that if he'd joined the war a little earlier, he could have stood shoulder to shoulder with the Three Saints. He was a monster among monsters.

Without the Blood Lord's impossible ability to recover, he would've died instantly several times over. And during the Sichuan Blood Tragedy, he fought the Western Heaven Demon Lord with a body that had only just recovered from being poisoned.

Of course, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, the most recent opponent he'd faced, was an exception.

The magical power flowing from the rift had turned her halfway into a monster. And after burning her innate qi, she'd displayed martial prowess beyond human limits.

But they weren't even taking Jeok Cheongang into account?

Bullshit.

I stared into the air, my gaze sinking as I thought.

The more I considered it, the more things didn't add up.

There was definitely something going on. Something I didn't know yet. An undisclosed secret.

And I knew one person who might answer at least some of my questions.

"Ma Sanbao."

At the name that slipped from my lips, Namho nodded as if he'd caught on.

"You're going to see him?"

"Yes. I think he'd know more about what's going on."

"Right. The East Depot's Brush-Holding Eunuch is famous for his resourcefulness. I suppose that's why he's been in charge of the East Depot for the past decade or so, acting as its de facto head."

Mentioning Ma Sanbao brought something else to mind.

I brought up a question I'd set aside for later.

"Has the Hidden Shadow Pavilion ever gathered information on the East Depot? Or on anything else concerning the imperial household?"

"I spent all my time holed up in Nanman, so I don't know the details. But I've heard they did quite a bit of that in the past."

"How far back?"

"Quite a while ago. Around the time of the Great Faction War… That was nearly fifty years ago now. Time really flies."

Fifty years.

Half a century.

As the years went by, the land and its people grew old.

Namho, one of the countless people carried along by those years, patted his lower back and continued.

"When the Demonic Cult swept down into the Central Plains, the Murim Alliance was formed. The Hidden Shadow Pavilion was established in the process. Where do you think we reached out first?"

"You mean…"

Namho grinned as he watched me hesitate.

"That's right. The place you're thinking of. The imperial household."

"…"

"Put simply, the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples amounted to an army of a hundred thousand invading from a foreign land. What's more, unlike the Central Plains, they had a single, unquestioned leader."

"They did. The Heavenly Demon, that son of a bitch."

Jeok Cheongang cut in, and Namho nodded.

"The problem was, that son of a bitch was effectively their king—or rather, practically a god."

That was why the Great Faction War had been so fierce, and why it had ended so quickly.

Unlike the orthodox faction, whose martial world was made up of people loyal to their own schools and leaders, those who followed the Demonic Path obeyed only one person: their Cult Leader, the Heavenly Demon.

It wasn't for nothing that people still said the world would have belonged to the Demonic Path if the orthodox faction hadn't had a new center of command in the

Martial God, and if its symbolic masters—including the Three Saints and the Ten Kings—hadn't fought so fiercely.

And to drive out the Heavenly Demon and his hundred thousand disciples, the Murim Alliance must have needed a powerful ally.

"So the Alliance reached out to the imperial household? To drive out the Heavenly Demon together?"

"That's right. If the Great Nation had helped us, everything would've been much easier."

Namho added bitterly, "Of course, the imperial household tested the waters for a while, then spat the idea out."

By this point, I was so curious that I couldn't help asking more.

It was a little removed from what I'd originally wanted to discuss, but I wanted to know why the imperial household hadn't intervened in the enormous battles that had erupted across the land during the Great Faction War.

"Why did they refuse? If a hundred thousand members of the Demonic Cult had invaded the Central Plains, surely the imperial household could've stepped in."

"I heard the late Emperor, who was the Son of Heaven at the time, opposed it personally."

"The late Emperor?"

"That's right. Several high ministers submitted memorials, but the young Emperor, who had only just ascended the throne, firmly shut his ears. The Great Nation had been founded less than twenty years earlier, so he said he needed to take care of the people."

At Namho's words, Jeok Cheongang snorted.

"Convincing-sounding bullshit, of course."

"Senior is right. They didn't want to risk the people's displeasure by mobilizing troops again, and they couldn't bear the cost of the damage. They trusted the orthodox Murim to act as a shield, then sat back to enjoy the show."

"It was foolish and indecisive. If the Demonic Cult had won the Great Faction War, the imperial household would've been next."

"The Hidden Shadow Pavilion came to the same conclusion. The Heavenly Demon was strong and ambitious. In the end, he would have brought down the Great Nation and established a theocracy. But as always, history is determined by its outcome, isn't it?"

Namho nodded and turned to me.

"After that, things went as everyone knows. The Heavenly Demon didn't want the imperial household involved either, so his forces advanced deep into the Central Plains while avoiding harm to ordinary people as much as possible. After more than a decade of fierce battles, the orthodox faction won by a miracle."

"That's it?"

"What else would there be? Oh, if I had to add anything, there are a few things people don't know. The indecisive young Son of Heaven, who'd only been afraid of war, became a sage king who'd protected the people through yet another conflict. And he ordered the East Depot and the Embroidered Uniform Guard to keep an even closer watch on martial artists."

"…"

"That's all. The imperial household had nearly been burned by an incident in the martial world, so in a way, it was only natural. After that, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion couldn't send agents into the imperial capital anymore. If the imperial household spotted and exposed them, we'd have to fight the Great Nation instead of the Demonic Cult."

After hearing about a past unknown to the world, I—and the other members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion—fell silent for a moment.

Even Taishan, who'd been quietly slaughtering the five-spice pork, was blinking. There was no denying it was a shocking story.

"Why are you only telling us this now?"

"Because it's in the past. We're busy enough dealing with the present without digging up ancient history."

Namho shrugged, then suddenly furrowed his brow.

"Wait, how did we end up talking about this? What was it you asked me at first?"

"I asked whether the Hidden Shadow Pavilion had ever gathered information on the East Depot. It didn't have to be the East Depot specifically—anything about the imperial household."

"Oh, right. Why did you ask?"

"Because I learned something a little unsettling a few shichen[3368] ago."

"Something unsettling? Is it connected to the East Depot?"

"Yes. More specifically, to Ma Sanbao. Eunuch Ma."

"If your ass feels dirty, you wipe it—even if you have to use your bare hand. Now tell me."

Jeok Cheongang delivered this filthy advice with needless solemnity, his eyes gleaming. With everyone looking at me, I slowly began to speak.

"Is there anyone Ma Sanbao might personally bring in from the martial world?"

"People from the martial world? Which sect?"

"I don't know what sect they belong to. And they're not exactly ordinary martial artists, either."

"What on earth are you talking about?"

"They're assassins."

"…"

[3368] A traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours.

At that moment, the gazes fixed on me swung in two directions.

Some toward Sama Pyo.

The rest toward the Divine Physician.

After a brief silence, the two of them spoke in turn, one young and one old.

“Wh-Why are you looking at me like that? I’m one of the good practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts.”

“I left that line of work a long time ago. N-No, I mean my Master…”

Was this what people meant when they said a guilty conscience needs no accuser?

Chapter 893

The reason everyone's eyes had turned to Sama Pyo and the Divine Physician—including mine—was simple.

They were both closely connected to the assassin business.

"Wh-Why are you looking at me like that? I'm one of the good practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts."

"I left that line of work a long time ago. I—No, I mean my Master…"

Of course, the two of them protested that it was unfair. Even so, there was no denying they had considerable ties to the world of assassins.

Especially in the case of someone whose Master had once been known as the terrifying Slaughter Saint.

"Now, now. I'm only asking, so calm down. Do you know anything? For example… an assassin group skilled and bold enough to sneak into the imperial palace?"

The Divine Physician looked around at us with darting eyes, then spoke as if he had no choice.

"How would I know something like that? It's true my Master was involved with that world once, but…"

"Involved? He was swimming in it."

At Jeok Cheongang's mutter, I nodded without thinking.

"Whew. He was practically flying around back then."

"Right. He flew around so much he eventually became a star."

"You make it sound like he's dead. He's still a living legend in that world."

"Of course. He rewrote history—with blood."

"Still, he didn't kill people for no reason."

"That came later. When he was young, he was probably no different from the rest of those bastards. And when you're young, you do what you're told."

The Divine Physician, who'd been listening to Jeok Cheongang and me go back and forth, gave us a look as cold as brine.

"If you're going to talk like that, I won't say another word."

"Come on, don't be like that. I'm only speaking loosely. You know how much I respect him."

"You're old enough to know better, yet here you are sulking. Say something. Surely you heard a thing or two from your Master."

After I tried to coax him, the Divine Physician hesitated for a moment, then let out a deep sigh.

"My Master was always reluctant to speak about his past."

I could understand that. The Slaughter Saint I knew regretted his bloodstained past.

That was why, right after the Great Faction War ended, he'd put everything behind him and started down the path of a physician.

Because he didn't want to kill anyone anymore.

He wanted to wash away the stench of blood that no amount of scrubbing could remove—not by killing, but by saving lives.

And so the greatest assassin of all time became the Divine Physician.

"However…"

The Divine Physician trailed off, then let out the breath he'd been holding.

"There were times when even my Master spoke of his past. Very rarely. Most of it was regretful rambling, but he did tell me about other assassins."

"Then, could it be…?"

"If they were assassins active in my Master's time, I've probably heard of them at least once. Of course, given what assassins are like, it's unlikely any of them are still active—"

"I'm glad we asked you first, sir."

"Pardon? What do you mean?"

"The assassin I saw today seems to fit those conditions perfectly."

"…!"

The Divine Physician's eyes widened. I told him—and everyone else waiting for me to continue—everything I'd seen and sensed, from beginning to end.

Even allowing for a human-skin mask or a disguise technique, the man had looked well over seventy. I told them about his martial prowess, too, and how he'd revealed his connection to Ma Sanbao himself.

When I finished, Ju Hwaran spoke, her eyes wide.

"That old man was a Supreme Peak master?"

"Yes. I'm sure of it."

"But how could an assassin… Ah, I'm sorry. I didn't mean it that way."

The Divine Physician waved a hand at her apology.

"No, it's all right. Though I've lived far removed from Murim, I know very well what it means for an assassin to reach the Supreme Peak realm."

It was common knowledge in Murim, and easy enough to understand, that assassins didn't reach the higher realms.

Even if you devoted yourself to a single path with a pure body and mind, setting foot in the Supreme Peak realm was like trying to pluck a star from the sky. What chance did assassins have when they had to learn all kinds of techniques just to survive and kill?

It's like trying to master your major while having to take dozens of extra electives.

That was why, judged purely by their martial arts, assassins were considered the weakest among those who practiced demonic, heterodox arts.

The Slaughter Saint's title as the greatest assassin of all time came from the same principle.

But the old man I'd met today had unquestionably been a Supreme Peak master.

He did have a slight physical disability, though.

"You said he walked with a limp?"

I nodded at the Divine Physician's question.

"Yes. I took a close look just in case, but it didn't seem faked. Besides, if he was disguising himself as a laborer carrying supplies, there'd be no reason to fake a limp."

"If Young Hero Jin says so, I believe you. Your reasoning makes sense, too. Still… a limp."

"Does anyone come to mind?"

The Divine Physician thought for a moment, then answered with a doubtful look.

"I can't say for certain, but my Master did tell me about someone like that. An assassin who once dominated Qinghai. His epithet was, if I remember right…"

"The One-Legged Ghost Killer?"

Someone cut in, and we all turned.

Sama Pyo flinched as everyone's gaze swung toward him, then spoke.

"I've heard of him. Though he was an assassin, his martial arts were so formidable that he sometimes killed his targets in life-and-death duels rather than through ambush."

"How do you know that?"

"How do you think? I heard about it."

"From who—Ah."

That was a pointless question.

Who was Sama Pyo? He might be getting worked like a dog under me, but he was the foremost young prodigy of the unorthodox factions and the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, which held sway over Qinghai alongside the Kunlun Sect.

And his father was none other than the Black Night King, Sima Gong.

The Black Night King Sima Gong was one of the Supreme Peak masters representing the demonic, heterodox arts. Despite his epithet, he wasn't one of the Ten Kings. But he'd fought on the Murim Alliance's side during the Great Faction War and built the Black Dragon Demon Gate into the formidable power it was today.

And since the Black Dragon Demon Gate's stronghold was in Qinghai, it would've been stranger if its Young Sect Leader *hadn't* heard a thing or two.

So, the One-Legged Ghost Killer.

“His epithet’s incredible. Just hearing it, he doesn’t sound like a good guy, does he?”

Sama Pyo nodded.

“He’s an assassin.”

“Why do you keep looking down on assassins? You practice demonic, heterodox arts yourself.”

“Even if you are the Pavilion Master, that’s harsh. I’m still one of the good, decent practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts.”

“What the fuck? Since when is there such a thing as a decent practitioner of demonic, heterodox arts? What are you, bright Dark Heaven?”

“…You really are too much.”

“Fine, I get it. You’re a decent guy. Whatever. Keep talking.”

Sama Pyo glared at Song Ilseom, who’d kept quiet until now but had started grinning like a lunatic the moment I laid into Sama Pyo, then spoke.

“They say the One-Legged Ghost Killer had a fearsome reputation throughout Qinghai even before the Great Faction War. His martial prowess was impressive, but his skill as an assassin was greater still. He was said to have killed an Elder of the Kunlun Sect who was a Supreme Peak master at the time.”

“He was that good?”

“At least, that’s what I’ve heard.”

“I see. All right. So?”

“So what?”

“Keep going.”

“That’s all. After the Great Faction War, I heard… his whereabouts became unknown.”

“…”

It felt like a fight had been going well until something came up and forced it to stop halfway through.

Fortunately, I had a walking encyclopedia of Murim beside me.

“Are you certain the old man you saw was the One-Legged Ghost Killer?”

Namho spoke up, rubbing his lower back.

“According to the information the Hidden Shadow Pavilion obtained, the One-Legged Ghost Killer is missing a leg. Of course, he usually wore a finely crafted prosthetic, so you’d need a keen eye to spot it.”

“You mean…”

“It means there’s a good chance you mistook him for someone else. Even if the man you saw really was the One-Legged Ghost Killer… for now, he’s an ally whether we like it or not.”

Namho’s last words rang louder than the rest.

An ally. An ally.

Just those two words left a bad taste in my mouth.

At the same time, I finally understood why the old assassin's presence had felt like a thorn in my throat.

I must be repulsed by the thought of getting mixed up with people like him.

If someone asked whether I thought I was a good person, I wouldn't be able to answer easily.

I'd taken countless lives myself.

Not monsters. Real people.

If I thought someone was an enemy, I killed them without hesitation. The faster I grew stronger, the easier killing became. I could have crippled them by destroying their dantian and severing the Sinews and Meridians in their limbs, but I couldn't find a reason to bother.

No. I didn't look for one.

I didn't want to leave even the slightest chance of future trouble.

And I'd learned that the more I thought about it—the more I looked back at how I'd slowly changed—the more it hurt.

There were no truly good people in Murim.

Only people who took others' lives and put their own on the line according to their goals and values.

That was why I couldn't call myself a good person, either.

I was only trying to become a little better.

Yesterday, today, and tomorrow.

And that was what repulsed me most about the old assassin.

Killing without a reason. Without even an excuse.

An assassin had only one reason to take a job, one purpose: money.

The old assassin wouldn't have tried to become a better person like the Slaughter Saint. He had killed, was killing, and would keep killing people for the numbers written on a bank draft.

Yesterday, today, and tomorrow.

And now, today, he'd become our dependable ally—a comrade who would fight back-to-back with us in the not-too-distant future.

Is this… right?

I found myself confused.

The two words Ma Sanbao had used—*the great undertaking*—weighed heavily on my heart. So did the image of the young king held captive in Qianqing Palace, dressed in splendid but cold clothes.

Just as I quietly smacked my lips at the bitter taste in my mouth, someone spoke in a calm voice.

“I once asked my Master why he’d ended the line of Salcheonmun, the sect where he was born and raised.”

The Divine Physician. It was him.

The old doctor, whose hair was snow-white unlike his Master’s, continued slowly.

“My Master said those who felt neither regret nor remorse for what they’d done deserved to die. And so he stained his hands with blood.”

“…!”

“Everyone has their own values, after all. My Master does. And so does Jin Taekyung.”

I couldn’t listen any longer.

I stood and headed outside.

I needed to see Ma Sanbao. I needed to settle this question: why had he brought them in?

Chapter 894

“Benefactor. No, Pavilion Master.”

At the sight of Jin Taekyung rising to his feet with a hardened expression, Ju Hwaran hurried to stop him.

Or tried to.

“Let him go.”

A quiet voice slipped into her ear.

The hand reaching toward Jin Taekyung froze in midair. Ju Hwaran looked at the door, firmly shut once more after a gust of wind and rain, then turned away.

“Was it really all right to let him go like that…?”

Jeok Cheongang, who had stopped her at the last moment, answered calmly.

“Who knows? How should this old man know?”

“Old Master!”

At Ju Hwaran’s reproachful cry, Jeok Cheongang gave a faint smile.

For a century and several decades, he had roamed Murim. He had seen all kinds of people over those years, and the enemies he had brought down were too many to count.

The name Fire King Jeok Cheongang belonged to history, past and present.

Even the leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families wouldn’t dare raise their voices in front of him.

So what had made that child so angry in front of the Fire King himself?

Jeok Cheongang knew the answer.

He also knew why his one and only Disciple had stormed out.

“I knew a monk for quite a long time. Night after night, he’d sneak off somewhere secluded to drink liquor and eat meat. A sham monk if ever there was one.”

Ju Hwaran paused at the abrupt story, then spoke carefully.

“Could you be talking about…?”

“That’s right. That sham monk was Hong Dao, the Dharma King.”

Their friendship was widely known.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang had a temper as fiery as his title, and hundreds—no, thousands—more enemies than friends. Of the few friends he did have, Hong Dao was the only one who could calm him with a few words.

Jeok Cheongang didn’t know it, but apart from his martial arts, Hong Dao’s ability to keep Jeok Cheongang’s foul temper in check had played a large part in earning him the title Dharma King.

Of course, the most decisive reasons Hong Dao was respected by all the Murim were his gentle nature—worthy of a great and virtuous monk—and his mysterious prophetic ability.

“Sometimes he’d read the heavenly patterns and learn the will of Heaven. It was a wondrous thing to watch.”

By now, everyone—including Ju Hwaran—was quietly listening to the story that had begun so suddenly.

The Dharma King was that symbolic a figure in the Central Plains Murim. Even if he hadn’t been the Abbot of Shaolin Temple, the very Mount Tai and Northern Dipper[3369] of the Murim, that wouldn’t have changed.

“But one year before that sham monk entered Nirvana,[3370] he told me something.”

Jeok Cheongang drew out a memory etched deep in his mind.

It was the memory of a night he could never return to, one that came back whenever he thought of the friend who had died before him.

“He said the heavenly patterns were becoming distorted. They had been for decades already. Before long, clouds of an unknown calamity would gather and cover the sun, the moon, and even the stars.”

“Dark Heaven…!”

A single cry slipped from someone’s lips.

Jeok Cheongang nodded and continued in a low voice.

“That was when I began to take the existence of Dark Heaven seriously.”

But that wasn’t all.

Four months before that conversation, Hong Dao had looked up at the sky and seen something shining amid the turbulent darkness.

“The Morning Star.”

Jeok Cheongang let out the breath he’d been holding.

A morning star was supposed to shine brilliantly for a moment, then fade.

But the one that had begun to shine clearly in the north never faded.

If anything, its light grew larger with each passing day.

It kept shining as Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung—an old man and a young man who had met by chance as though by fate—left Shanxi and reached Henan.

It kept shining through the year they spent together on Mount Jiuhua, until the venerable monk who had first discovered it became a handful of relics.

And perhaps it was still shining now.

“Do you know what the Dharma King said when he told me about the Morning Star?”

[3369] “Mount Tai and Northern Dipper” is a Chinese honorific for a preeminent authority in a field.

[3370] In Buddhism, nirvana is liberation from the cycle of rebirth. “Entered Nirvana” can also be a respectful way to say that a monk has died.

No one answered, and Jeok Cheongang didn’t wait for them to.

“He said that one insolent brat I’d kept by my side was the master of that Morning Star.”

“…!”

“He said that even if the whole world were plunged into darkness one day, that Morning Star would never lose its light.”

Everyone stared, mouths agape.

The subject of this astonishing secret from the past, unknown until now, was someone they all knew well.

Jin Taekyung.

The same name struck every one of them.

The shock was greater than any of them could have imagined.

Hong Dao himself, the Dharma King, had named him the master of the Morning Star that would light the world. A star that would never lose its light, even at the end.

But the Morning Star pointed neither to the Martial God, now a legend of the past, nor to the Sword Saint, who was writing a legend of his own as the new Murim Alliance Leader.

It pointed to Jin Taekyung.

A young man barely past twenty who had nevertheless shone brighter than anyone amid the calamity sweeping the land.

Clunk. Whoosh.

In the silence that had settled over the pavilion, a fierce gust of wind and rain flung open the firmly shut door.

Rain and wind swept among them, no weaker than before, but no one spoke.

As if by agreement, they turned their heads and gazed into the darkness outside, their eyes still wide with shock.

At the place where the star had been.

Toward the master of the Morning Star, somewhere out there.

“I once heard someone say this.”

Jeok Cheongang murmured calmly.

“Where a star shines, darkness gathers. But the star never disappears.”

At first, Jeok Cheongang himself had been skeptical.

A calamity that would dwarf the Great Faction War?

Jin Taekyung, so young he was practically an infant, the light amid that calamity?

But as time passed, and the longer Jeok Cheongang watched Jin Taekyung at his side, the more he came to understand.

This brat is the light. A new star to guide us through the darkness that will one day cover the land.

And…

The only light Heaven has granted this old man.

Just as a star shone brighter in the darkness, darkness always seemed to gather wherever Jin Taekyung went.

Yet none of it had dared touch him. None had extinguished the light he gave off.

And even if such a day came, it would not be this time.

Complete darkness had not yet fallen over the land. Only then would the Morning Star that was Jin Taekyung shine its biggest and brightest.

Until then… find your own path. Shine your light wherever you wish.

Jeok Cheongang smiled faintly.

He had long since passed the age of weighing the rights and wrongs of the world.

There was no justice in the Murim he had known—or in this world at all.

Only monsters consumed by their own causes, pointing spears and swords at one another.

Just like the incomprehensible series of events unfolding right here, in the imperial palace.

This old man is no different.

Growing old also meant growing numb.

Death had become cheap, and the people he had struggled to let into his heart had begun to leave, one by one.

His first Disciple, Jangcheon. The Dharma King.

The justice Jeok Cheongang had chosen, his great cause, was to protect what he had left.

He only hoped to make even a slightly good choice along the way, as his one and only Disciple—who had suddenly come into his life late in the old man's years—was doing.

To Jeok Cheongang, that was the only difference between the orthodox faction and practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts.

Even if you write it clumsily, all crooked and awkward, does that make its meaning fade?

Even if the handwriting was terrible, the meaning contained in the character for *upright* remained unchanged. It was simply as awkward as a child's writing.

And his Disciple, Jin Taekyung, despised the assassins who didn't even make that effort. He suspected Ma Sanbao's motives for suddenly bringing martial artists into the cause.

Whatever you decide, it doesn't matter. This old man will always be at your side.

Jeok Cheongang gazed into the darkness through the door the wind had thrown wide open.

The imperial palace was unknown territory, full of secrets.

Whatever happened next, it wouldn't surprise him.

No—a storm was already raging, so vast it was impossible to tell friend from foe.

If we can't avoid it, we'll have to face it.

Jeok Cheongang muttered inwardly, then smacked Taishan on the back of the head. Taishan had been licking a bare plate clean.

Smack!

"Quit doing the dishes and close the door, you unorthodox bastard."

It didn't take long for me to come face-to-face with Ma Sanbao.

He found me before I found him.

"He's waiting for you."

I was heading toward the pavilion assigned to the East Depot, picturing the layout I'd already learned, when a eunuch in a close-fitting martial uniform approached and spoke. My eyes narrowed.

How did he know?

I'd made sure to stay hidden using the darkness and the terrain, and I'd kept my movements to a minimum.

No matter how skilled the East Depot eunuchs were with concealment techniques, it was hard to believe they could detect someone of my caliber so easily.

But…

Damn it.

Right now, I had to set the question aside and keep going. I stepped quietly out of the darkness, and the eunuch led me to a small pavilion.

"He's waiting inside."

I quickly surveyed the area.

The imperial palace was divided into countless pavilions and sections for its various departments.

But this wasn't the East Depot's section, according to the palace map I'd obtained from Ma Sanbao beforehand.

"Wait. This place…"

"It isn't a building assigned to the East Depot. Officially, that is."

"…"

"Then I'll take my leave."

A secret refuge in the imperial palace, used to avoid people's eyes. Something like that?

The eunuch vanished before I could ask anything else. I went inside.

Creak.

For once, the foul weather was useful.

The old wooden door's groan was swallowed by the pounding rain.

Ma Sanbao is… upstairs.

There was only one presence on the floor above. I climbed the stairs, which creaked almost as badly as the door, and saw a lone figure standing in the pitch-black room.

"You came?"

In the darkness, I caught a glimpse of teeth far whiter than those of an ordinary person of this era.

Ma Sanbao glanced around the room, empty of so much as a candle or a piece of furniture, and shrugged.

"Forgive the humble setting. Too many eyes are watching."

"This is fine. I can put up with this much."

"This much? Sounds like there's something else you can't put up with."

"Since you already know, we should be able to finish this conversation quickly."

The voice coming out of my mouth sounded like a stranger's. My expression was probably just as stiff.

"As expected. You're astonishingly honest."

"I hear that a lot."

How often did anyone speak that way to Ma Sanbao, the East Depot's de facto leader?

But he didn't react as I'd expected.

"So, what do you want to hear about?"

His face was calm, as if he'd known this was coming. Then he spoke again, his voice just as composed.

"The assassins I hired? Or… that woman, So Gyo?"

"…!"

Chapter 895

The pavilion's interior was as dark as a cave.

I listened to the heavy rain outside the window and quietly turned over what Ma Sanbao had just said. I thought, too, of the eunuch who'd led me here as if he'd been waiting for me all along.

"You already knew?"

Ma Sanbao nodded.

"About two shichen[3371] ago, the assassins reported that you'd discovered who they were. They were concerned it might interfere with the job."

You'd have to be remarkably oblivious not to realize that *concerned* was putting it mildly.

Especially when the people involved were assassins.

"So the assassins you hired wanted to kill me."

"Not exactly. But you know what kind of people assassins are."

"I've never dealt with them firsthand, but I have a general idea. And you brought people like that into this."

"I had no choice. Pay them a fair price, and they're more loyal than anyone."

"So what did you tell them to do about me?"

"…My friend."

Ma Sanbao studied me with a furrowed brow, then went on with a sigh.

"Don't mistake me for a madman like the Son of Heaven. You came all this way, a thousand li,[3372] to help His Highness Prince Shangshan. They're merely assassins carrying out a job they were promised payment for. Which of you is the more trustworthy ally?"

"Well…"

"You, of course. Is that enough of an answer?"

Not yet.

I barely managed to keep the words from coming out.

Right. Not yet.

Was it everything I'd experienced up to now? Or had my head simply grown as cold as the rain outside?

Instinct told me it would be a bad idea to lay all my thoughts bare. Instead, I nodded as if I accepted his answer and brought up the question I'd set aside.

"Then did you know about So Gyo, too?"

[3371] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

[3372] This uses the Korean ri, approximately 393 m (0.244 mi). A thousand ri are about 393 km (244 mi).

“No. I deliberately withheld information about the assassins because I knew how people like you in Murim would see them, but… she’s different.”

The shadow I thought I saw fall over Ma Sanbao’s face wasn’t just a trick of the darkness.

“We didn’t tell you about that woman who goes by So Gyo because we didn’t know much about her ourselves.”

“You didn’t know? The East Depot, of all people?”

The Embroidered Uniform Guard and the East Depot were vast intelligence organizations with roots all across the land. Even after the East Depot’s power had diminished in the wake of the coup, it was hard to believe it could have missed what was happening in the imperial palace—practically its own stronghold.

“Tell me more.”

“All right. Perhaps it’ll give you a little more reason to trust me.”

Reading the distrust in my eyes, Ma Sanbao smiled bitterly.

“It was more than ten years ago that So Gyo—or rather, an unidentified master—first appeared.”

His voice carried through the rain as it slowly began to ease.

He finished his story.

Ma Sanbao had spoken without pause for about fifteen minutes. He took a flask from his belt, while I stared at him, bewildered.

“Why are you only telling me all this now? If I’d known sooner…”

“I was afraid.”

Ma Sanbao had just raised the flask to his lips. He went on.

“It may sound like an excuse, but I couldn’t help it. I didn’t think the forces I’ve gathered so far would be able to handle her.”

The sharp smell of liquor drifted from the mouth of the flask. Noticing my gaze, Ma Sanbao tossed it to me.

“Want a drink? You look like you could use one.”

I caught it on reflex. After a moment’s hesitation, I brought it to my lips.

After a story like that, I needed a drink. I could have drunk a whole jar without getting particularly drunk anyway, so I took several long gulps.

It burned on the way down, its sharp aroma filling my mouth. Strong liquor—the cheap kind sold at any inn in the land.

“Maybe it’s because you’re from the north, but you certainly know how to drink.”

I grimaced and swallowed what was still in my mouth.

“I’m surprised. I thought you’d drink something better.”

“What, you thought the East Depot’s Brush-Holding Eunuch was too good for cheap strong liquor?”

Ma Sanbao gave a quiet laugh and shook his head.

“No matter how high I’ve risen, strong liquor is what I am at heart. I came from the bottom, just like this liquor you can find anywhere. And like it, I don’t readily reveal what I keep inside. To survive in the imperial palace, you have to hide your feelings behind a sharp smell like this one. In that sense, perhaps So Gyo and I are alike.”

So Gyo.

I turned the name over in my mind, along with the unbelievable story I’d just heard.

“Is it all true?”

“What do you think? Does it sound like a lie?”

“I want an answer.”

“If you want my word, then yes. Every bit of it is true. I’ll stake my life on it.”

Ma Sanbao’s face was grave as he answered. Then he turned toward the window.

Beyond it, the rain had grown much lighter. His eyes, fixed on the thinning rain, had sunk deep.

“I can say this much for certain: without So Gyo, the coup that day would never have succeeded. Cang Gong wouldn’t be bedridden as he is now, either.”

So Gyo had first appeared more than ten years ago, on the day the imperial palace was engulfed in war.

“Hong Jin may not have known, since he stayed by the late Emperor’s side throughout, but as I said, the East Depot did everything it could to stop the coup.”

If Ma Sanbao’s story was true, Cang Gong—now laid low by illness—had been a remarkable man.

He had served the late Emperor even before Baek Yeon, and Ma Sanbao said his martial arts were on a level comparable to Baek Yeon’s, despite Baek being hailed as the strongest warrior in the imperial family.

“Lord Cang Gong was the first to sense something was wrong. He summoned the Imperial Guards from the outskirts of the Imperial Capital and moved to repel the rebels with the East Depot forces inside the palace.”

Ma Sanbao had served under Cang Gong at the time. He’d believed they stood a good chance if they could defeat the Embroidered Uniform Guard in the palace and take back the late Emperor.

Until one person appeared.

“The life-and-death duel between Baek Yeon and Lord Cang Gong was evenly matched. If it had stayed that way, we could have put down the coup. Once the Imperial Guards joined us, even the Embroidered Uniform Guard couldn’t have held out. But…”

Ma Sanbao's voice hardened.

"Things don't always go the way you want."

An unidentified master dressed entirely in black appeared, and the tide turned sharply against them.

Cang Gong couldn't withstand the combined assault of the two Supreme Peak masters. He collapsed with severe Internal Injuries, and the balance of the battle fell apart.

"Our forces were by no means weaker than the Embroidered Uniform Guard. The only reason we lost was that figure in black… No, that unidentified master we now call So Gyo."

Ma Sanbao reached for the flask I'd handed back to him, as though his throat had gone dry. But his fingers had begun to tremble, and it slipped from his hand.

It struck the floor with a hollow thud and rolled away. Liquor spilled from the half-full flask.

Ma Sanbao stared at the spreading puddle, his eyes heavy, and murmured as if to himself.

"What I saw her do that day was… chilling. In the face of that overwhelming aura, I couldn't do a thing."

I suddenly remembered So Gyo's energy, calm as a spring breeze from beginning to end. And the terrifying wave of power that surged from her in that brief instant.

"She surely wasn't even going all out."

Was this what it felt like to face a wall you could never climb?

I'd met countless powerful people, allies and enemies alike. Fewer than ten had ever made me feel that kind of pressure.

And every one of them belonged to the Three Saints or was a master who could stand as their equal.

They had gone beyond Supreme Peak, the realm every martial artist dreamed of, and stepped into something higher.

Jeok Cheongang had finally reached the realm of Returned to Youth after casting off the Heart Demon that had worn away at his mind and body for years. So Gyo, too, was a master for whom even *a match for ten thousand men* was no exaggeration.

"So that's why you chose me. No—me and my Master."

"That's right. Just as I told you before."

With the truth laid bare, Ma Sanbao continued grimly.

"Someone who would come a thousand li[3373] to help Prince Shangshan. Someone who would put human decency ahead of any reward. And…"

[3373] This uses the Korean ri, approximately 393 m (0.244 mi). A thousand ri are about 393 km (244 mi).

“Another master capable of facing the unidentified expert at the Emperor’s side. The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. Am I right?”

Ma Sanbao was silent for a moment, then nodded weakly.

“Exactly. That’s why I put your name in the secret letter to Hong Jin. If Jeok Cheongang’s only Disciple risked going to the imperial palace, it wasn’t hard to guess his Master would come too.”

“Then you knew everything that happened in Nanman?”

“I’d been watching for some time. Not Nanman—you.”

“Why didn’t you formally ask the Murim Alliance for help? Wouldn’t that have been much better?”

“I know quite a bit about its current Alliance Leader, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak. Cang Gong once called him one of the few true chivalrous heroes left in this age.”

“Then why choose me or my Master?”

“The fewer people who know a secret, the better. Especially when the secret is a coup.”

“Ah.”

At my low murmur, Ma Sanbao smiled bitterly.

“We call ourselves a restoration army, but to the rest of the world, we’re traitors. And if our ties to Murim came to light, nothing good would come of it.”

Murim was a forest within the borders of the Great Nation, but its people also openly defied the laws of the land.

If the Murim Alliance intervened, it would be like bringing a foreign force into this crucial fight for the throne. A pack of beasts beyond the fence, without even leashes to restrain them.

“Of course, the current Alliance Leader likely wants to help us. The secret order he gave you to guard Prince Shangshan tells me as much.”

“That’s true. We also have to keep a close eye on every move the imperial family makes.”

“But that’s as far as he can go. If he asked the Alliance to formally join the restoration army, how many of its leaders would agree?”

“Well…”

My voice trailed off.

A coup.

Just thinking of the word sent a chill down my spine.

The Heavenly Demon, who supposedly ruled the Demonic Cult like a king, might have been able to make that decision alone. An elected Alliance Leader could not.

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families. And all the other sects beneath the Murim Alliance’s banner.

Winning the support of most of them would be next to impossible. Right or wrong, a coup was a gamble that could ruin entire families in an instant.

“And so, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, I ask you formally.”

The rain that had poured down without letup had stopped as if by magic. Ma Sanbao’s eyes flashed in the darkness.

“Will you join forces with me—no, with us?”

His voice rang clear, full of force.

“Will you help us set this troubled land to rights and put His Highness Prince Shangshan on the throne?”

“…!”

My body trembled before I could stop it.

A bolt of lightning struck through the tangled mess in my head.

For a moment I said nothing, staring at Ma Sanbao. The silence was brief, yet it felt longer than any I’d known. Then I spoke.

“Do you still have that joint pledge you showed me last time?”

At the meaning behind my words, a bright smile spread across Ma Sanbao’s face.

Chapter 896

The pledge Ma Sanbao pulled from his robe was worn with age.

The paper had yellowed, and stains marked it here and there. But the names and positions, crowded onto it in each signer's own hand, were still clear. At the center stood one name in larger, bolder script than all the rest.

Wei Zhong, Seal-Holding Eunuch of the East Depot.

"Lord Cang Gong," Ma Sanbao said, noticing where I was looking. "He was the first to draw up the pledge and sign it. He made us promise, again and again, that even if he died, we would see the coup through."

"He must have thought he might die."

"His Internal Injury was so severe it would have been no surprise if he'd died on the spot. Thankfully, he survived…"

Ma Sanbao sighed, regret on his face.

"But it's not good. He still hasn't recovered completely. Of course, if he hadn't been injured that badly, he wouldn't still be alive."

"What do you mean?"

"Why else would the Emperor have spared Lord Cang Gong? He was the foremost of the old retainers who served the late Emperor. The Emperor couldn't execute him outright without facing the consequences."

I'd wondered about that myself.

That meticulous Emperor had spared Lord Cang Gong, the man who stood in his way—and the head of the East Depot, the most threatening force of all.

"Is there something else I don't know?"

Ma Sanbao nodded quietly.

"There was a bargain. The fate of the Great Nation hung on it."

"What kind of bargain?"

"The life of a child who hadn't even learned to walk. Traded for the lives of countless loyal officials."

"…!"

"Yes, exactly what you're thinking. Nearly a hundred senior officials were sacrificed to save His Highness Prince Shangshan. Not just the officials themselves, but their entire families."

The air around us seemed to grow heavy. A fire flickered in Ma Sanbao's eyes.

"With the late Emperor, His Highness the Crown Prince, and the other princes all gravely ill, we had to protect His Highness Prince Shangshan, our last hope, even at that cost. It was the only way."

"What did the Emperor get out of the bargain?"

“Legitimacy and time. The late Emperor, after securing a promise about His Highness Prince Shangshan’s future, formally abdicated the throne. Lord Cang Gong calmed the opposition forces that had wanted to fight the new Emperor.”

The Imperial Capital might be the center of the realm, but it wasn’t the whole realm.

The Great Nation’s vast territories were held together by countless officials and armies. Even with the legitimacy of a formal transfer of power, the new Emperor would have needed time to quell the unrest simmering across the land.

Cang Gong was the most respected of the late Emperor’s old retainers. Cang Gong’s safety, along with Prince Shangshan’s, must have been what kept those forces in check.

“The bargain dealt us a terrible blow, but it let us achieve what we had to. The Emperor wasn’t the only one who needed time to recover.”

The Emperor had probably expected Cang Gong to die before long.

Instead, Cang Gong had miraculously survived his terrible Internal Injury. The East Depot he led had endured, too.

And so had the restoration army, which dreamed of rebellion under his leadership.

“So the two sides split apart and faced off against each other. And they’ve been doing that for more than a decade.”

“That’s right. This clash has been inevitable for a long time. We’ve had our blades pointed at each other, but neither side could make the first move. Not openly, at least.”

I frowned at that last part.

“Not openly?”

“There have been several assassination attempts. The Emperor went after Lord Cang Gong, and we went after the Emperor.”

I didn’t need to ask how those attempts had turned out. Both men were still alive.

The Emperor lived under heavy guard in Qianqing Palace, though. Cang Gong’s survival was the surprising part.

“When I went to Qianqing Palace, I saw that the Emperor had one hell of an assassin working for him. How did you stop them?”

“The Emperor has several Supreme Peak masters under his command, of course. But our forces are no weaker. Have you heard of the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac?”

“I’ve heard the name a few times. Aren’t those constellations?”

“Usually. But it’s also a title for the twelve Supreme Peak masters who protect the Imperial Capital.”

What?

My eyes widened. Twelve Supreme Peak masters, all here in the Imperial Capital? They were rare even in Murim.

I knew much of the Great Nation's strength was concentrated here, but that was still astonishing. What Ma Sanbao said next surprised me even more.

"Half of those twelve Supreme Peak masters belong to our side. Some of them are staying with Lord Cang Gong."

"…!"

"And that's not all."

Ma Sanbao pointed to the names and positions on the pledge, one after another.

Among them was an old scholar who enjoyed the overwhelming support of the realm's Confucian scholars, along with senior court officials of the highest rank, such as the Three Dukes. But the most important names belonged to military officers.

Commanders guarding the Imperial Capital and the borders beyond it. One was even a governor-general who commanded tens of thousands of troops.

"Do you understand why this standoff has lasted so long?"

I nodded gravely.

The names on that pledge represented no less than half the Great Nation. If either side struck first, the result would be a sea of corpses and blood.

"The Emperor is the one who drew his sword first. We had no intention of upsetting the balance. We wanted to wait, at least until His Highness Prince Shangshan was older."

Children of this era generally grew up faster than children in the modern world. But Prince Shangshan was still too young to shoulder the burden of an empire this vast.

"His Highness the Crown Prince was so gifted. The two princes and the other members of the imperial family were worthy of their station, too. Yet they all fell ill, wasted away, and died. Just like someone you know."

"…The City Lord of Sichuan Province."

"Yes. He, too, supposedly fell ill that way just after meeting the Emperor. Do you think that's a coincidence?"

Ma Sanbao's voice was grave, but there was no doubt in it.

"The Emperor must have joined forces with that sinister group called Dark Heaven. Baek Yeon, who suddenly betrayed the late Emperor, and that woman So Gyo must be closely tied to them as well."

"…!"

"You and I have come too far to turn back. It's time to end this long, terrible turmoil. The grand banquet…"

His eyes gleamed.

"It will be the grand enthronement of a new Son of Heaven. The rightful one."

I closed my eyes without realizing it.

Darkness.

The rain had spent itself in one furious downpour, and I could no longer hear it.

The silence was suffocating.

In it, I turned my thoughts and doubts over once more.

What was right? What was wrong?

What waited at the end of this choice?

The die had already been cast.

I'd made my decision the moment I asked Ma Sanbao for the pledge. This was only the last fork in the road to where I was going.

Rustle.

I opened my eyes to Ma Sanbao's rigid face. After watching him in silence for a while, I brought my hand to my mouth.

Crack. Tap.

A dull pain, and drops of blood began to fall. With my pinky finger wet with blood, I filled in the pledge's empty space.

Jin Taekyung.

Three characters. Nothing more.

Unlike the others who had crowded the pledge with their names, I added no sobriquet, family, or affiliation.

Ma Sanbao understood at once.

"You mean to shoulder the burden alone. In case the coup fails."

"Does that make me a coward?"

"No. I can't blame you. You don't want to suffer the same fate as the Maoshan Sect, annihilated for opposing the Great Nation in the past. Besides…"

He tucked the pledge, now bearing my name, into his robe.

"If you and your Master join us, the coup won't fail."

He looked and sounded certain. I watched him for a moment, then spoke.

"That's not enough."

What?

"Not 'it won't fail.' It *has* to succeed, doesn't it?"

"What are you—"

Before Ma Sanbao could finish, I went to the bookcase in the corner of the pavilion and pulled out a book. I tore out a page without hesitation, scrawled a short message on it with my still-bleeding finger, and handed it to him.

"What is this…?"

He frowned at the writing.

“I have no idea what it means. I can barely read it.”

“That’s because it’s in code.”

“Code?”

“A cipher only a handful of people can understand.”

“Then why are you—wait. You don’t mean…”

“I do.”

I nodded at Ma Sanbao, whose eyes had widened, and continued slowly.

“Send one of your men to the place I’m about to tell you and have him deliver that message. Reinforcements from the Murim Alliance will arrive in time for the grand banquet. A powerful force that might even include the Slaughter Saint or one of the Ten Kings.”

“…!”

“You told me last time: succeed, and we’re kings. Fail, and we’re traitors.”

I met Ma Sanbao’s face, colored with shock and amazement, and muttered,

“In that case, shouldn’t we make sure this coup succeeds?”

Yes.

The die had already been cast.

The downpour was almost without precedent.

Rain had battered the Imperial Capital overnight, flooding parts of the city. Hundreds of homes were submerged, and many people were killed or injured.

In its wake, ominous rumors began to spread.

They said they’d found a venomous serpent in a well on the outskirts of the capital—one bigger than several grown men put together.

They said it was Heaven’s warning to the current Son of Heaven, who had defied the natural order—and a prophecy that an even greater disaster was about to begin.

They said the rain had stopped so soon thanks to His Highness Prince Shangshan, who had carried on the late Emperor’s will.

Rumors like these, steeped in superstition, spread like wildfire. Within two days, they had crossed the city’s towering walls and reached the imperial palace.

They reached even its deepest, most secluded place: Qianqing Palace.

When the Emperor heard them, he gave an irritable laugh.

“Looks like the time has come.”

It was the first sign of a storm.

It was also the beginning of the grand banquet—and the wind, rain, and sea of corpses and blood it would bring.

Chapter 897

That day, everything was different from usual.

The streets, usually filled with laughter and music, were quiet. Clouds that had yet to clear cast shadows over the people below, and the canal, swollen by unprecedented rainfall, churned uneasily, as if reflecting the mood of the city.

At the end of it all, and at its center, stood the imperial palace.

Rumble.

It was the dim hour before dawn. Even when the massive iron gates began to open with a heavy metallic groan, no one thought anything strange was happening.

The palace gates always closed at the hour of the Rat[3374] and opened at the hour of the Rabbit.[3375]

Before long, dawn would break. Ministers from the various courts would make their way to the palace, while the people of this beautiful, dangerous metropolis—high and low alike—began another day in their own places.

Like precisely meshing gears.

As if that were simply the natural order of things.

But the dazzling light that appeared between the slowly opening gates was proof that this day would not begin like any other.

“H-Hey. Is that…?”

“Hm?”

A vendor who had set up his stall along the main road in front of the palace, as usual, turned at the call of a fellow merchant. His narrow eyes swelled wide.

“T-The Embroidered Uniform Guard?”

The words had barely escaped his lips when—

“Ha!”

With a short battle cry shouted in unison, a thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards mounted on their fine steeds poured through the wide-open gates.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Hooves thundered, waking the dawn.

The ground shook. Dust, settled by the cool morning air and rainwater that had yet to dry, rose into the air.

The thousand riders shot forward like a single arrow, crossing the main road before the palace in the blink of an eye. At a hand signal from their commander, they scattered in every direction.

From a thousand to hundreds. Hundreds to a hundred. A hundred to dozens.

They split up, then split again, exactly as planned.

[3374] The hour of the Rat is the traditional two-hour period from 11 p.m. to 1 a.m.

[3375] The hour of the Rabbit is the traditional two-hour period from 5 a.m. to 7 a.m.

The people who had started their day early watched in a daze. But when they saw the notices left behind by the golden tide that had swept through the Imperial Capital, they understood.

Tomorrow. The hour of the Goat.[3376]

The grand banquet for the imperial prince's birthday. Begins.

That was how the first line of the hundreds of proclamations began, each written by the imperial court calligrapher whose elegant handwriting was renowned throughout the realm. The faces of the people already suffering from the untimely flood twisted with anger.

"Three days? He's holding that damn banquet for three whole days in a situation like this?"

"Shh. Keep your voice down. Want to get arrested for treason?"

"Treason, my ass. I worked like an ox my whole life to buy my house, and now I've lost it and every last thing in it. What have I got left to be afraid of?"

"Exactly!"

"Fuck, so to hell with what the people think? His own kid's birthday comes first, is that it?"

Some had lost their property. Others, their families.

And they were all neighbors who had been closer than family.

So the people trying to calm those furious at the proclamation didn't look happy, either.

The Son of Heaven. Or the Emperor.

How could the supreme ruler, descended from the dragon appointed by Heaven and charged with caring for all his subjects, do such a thing?

Those who had lost what they treasured in the flood were furious. And the people watching them suddenly realized that they too might one day be standing there, furious over their own losses.

Something's wrong with this country…

At first, they had done nothing but look up to the Son of Heaven. He was so far above them that they couldn't dream of seeing him, no different from the sun overhead.

But the current Emperor had violated the bonds of kinship.

He was a monster in human skin who had seized the throne by slaughtering his parents, his siblings, and countless loyal officials and their families.

And so Heaven's favor must have turned away from him.

At the Shaolin Temple, known to everyone under Heaven, eminent monks had been dying. In Sichuan, thousands of martial artists had turned the broad daylight into a sea of corpses and blood.

[3376] The hour of the Goat is the traditional two-hour period from 1 p.m. to 3 p.m.

And that wasn’t all.

Unbelievable rumors had come from Hubei of an imugi gone on a rampage. Sinister tales said that the barbarians of the harsh lands of Nanman had formed a vast army and marched north.

The northern tribes, quiet as mice for a hundred years, were showing signs of unrest. And now an unprecedented downpour had struck the Imperial Capital.

What could this string of disasters mean?

Heaven has forsaken this country. No—the heavens are trying to punish the Emperor.

If these had been peaceful, prosperous times, no one would have given such rumors and superstitions a second thought.

A house earned through hard work, a beloved family, plenty of grain and money—that would have been enough.

For more than a decade, the realm had been as calm as the waters of West Lake. The people hadn’t complained about their new Son of Heaven as much as one might have expected.

They could condemn the Son of Heaven for defying the natural order, but their lives and livelihoods hadn’t changed all that much.

Some had even cheered when corrupt officials who’d run rampant during the late Emperor’s peaceful reign were caught up in the purge for treason. Good riddance, they’d said.

But things were different now.

In barely two years, strange phenomena that could only be called supernatural powers had appeared throughout the realm. A young king beloved by the people had been summoned to the capital. And the Son of Heaven, ignoring his suffering subjects, had poured a fortune into a banquet celebrating his heir.

“Is this… is this truly the right thing to do?”

A man in a worn bamboo hat pulled low over his face muttered the question on everyone’s mind.

“The people’s will is Heaven’s will, and Heaven’s will is the people’s. Why, then, has the Emperor turned his back on Heaven and his people?”

His voice rang clearly through the crowd, which had fallen silent.

The invisible air pressed down on them, heavy and still.

In the suffocating silence, people clenched their teeth and their eyes shone. For some reason, they strained to hear every word of the man’s voice, which sounded unusually clear.

“The azure heaven’s power is waning, and dark clouds gather. The storm that will soon descend will soon swallow the realm whole.”

It was strange.

Hundreds of people had gathered there, yet not one of them spoke. They all listened to the man.

The rough laborer who had never learned to read. The street vendor who lived from day to day. Even the elderly Confucian scholar, whose learning was likely as extensive as his years.

There was something mysterious in the man's words and voice, a profound insight and conviction that drew them all in.

And left them with a question they couldn't help asking.

"Um, sir. Forgive me for interrupting, but could I ask you one thing?"

At the laborer's cautious approach, rough as he looked, the man in the bamboo hat nodded.

"Go ahead."

"If it's not too much trouble, what should a poor man like me do to escape the storm you mentioned?"

"Head for the mountain."

"What?"

The laborer's eyes widened at the answer, given without a moment's hesitation. The man in the bamboo hat continued slowly.

"Find the highest mountain in the realm and take shelter there. It has a stream that never runs dry, fruit growing ripe, and animals roaming free. Its forests will provide timber for homes and firewood. It could shelter all the people under Heaven and still have room to spare."

The laborer was dumbfounded.

So was most of the crowd.

The highest mountain in the realm?

Where was there a mountain vast enough to shelter everyone, with food and resources to spare?

While the laborer searched for words, another man, more impatient, blurted out,

"I don't know who you are, but you seem to be a master of profound cultivation. Do you mean the Five Sacred Mountains of the Central Plains?"

A few people gave soft cries of recognition and nodded.

The five famous mountains, said to be the highest in the realm and filled with sacred energy—yes, that would make sense, they murmured.

"Which of the Five Sacred Mountains do you mean? Mount Song in Henan? Taishan in Shandong? Huashan in Shaanxi? Or…"

"You're all wrong. I didn't mean the Five Sacred Mountains of the Central Plains."

"What? What do you mean? If not the Five Sacred Mountains, then what—"

The man's calm, firm reply left the crowd speechless. Just then, an elderly voice came from somewhere among them.

"There's one place left. No, it was the only place from the beginning."

Every head turned.

An elderly Confucian scholar in faded but neat clothes gazed at the gloomy sky and murmured, almost to himself,

"Shangshan."

"…!"

A few people understood what those words meant, and their eyes widened. Most remained confused.

Until the old scholar continued.

"Yes. That place could shelter all the people under Heaven. No matter how fiercely the storm swallowed the Five Sacred Mountains of the Central Plains, it would never dare reach Shangshan. The mountain's master is under Heaven's protection, a descendant of the dragon who commands rain and lightning."

For a moment, the world seemed to stop.

Everyone stood frozen like statues, looking at one another. Then they realized they had all reached the same conclusion.

Shangshan.

Higher and wider than the Five Sacred Mountains of the Central Plains, a mountain capable of sheltering all the people under Heaven.

And its master—a descendant of the dragon, protected by Heaven.

How had they failed to see it? How could they have been so foolish?

The man had never been talking about a mountain. Every word had pointed to one person who could shelter this troubled realm.

Prince Shangshan…!

Was this what it felt like to have a bolt of lightning strike through the crown of your head?

Everyone's whole body trembled as if they'd been electrocuted.

Mouths agape. Teeth clenched. Fists balled, as they fought to cool their heads, burning hot with excitement.

And at the same time, they pictured a future they had never imagined before.

What if… what if His Highness Prince Shangshan took the throne?

Heaven's favor had already departed. The people's hearts were wavering.

And a child who had survived the vast, brutal purge years ago had returned to the capital, to the very place where he had first cried out at birth.

Was it fate, or coincidence? Another sinister plot by an Emperor who had already violated the bonds of kinship once?

Or…

Was it the Mandate of Heaven?

No one dared speak. Slowly, they turned their heads.

They wanted an answer.

They wanted to face the man who had put this startling possibility before them.

But in the next moment, their anticipation and excitement came crashing down.

The place where the man in the bamboo hat had stood only moments ago was empty.

Chapter 898

Someone once said humans are creatures of adaptation.

But everyone has at least one thing they can never get used to, no matter how many times they experience it.

For me, one was being responsible for other people's lives. Another was waking up to someone's ugly face.

"What are you doing?"

Hyuk Mujin answered, "Checking on you, Captain."

"Why?"

"You barred everyone from coming in and spent two whole days shut up in your room circulating your qi. I thought you might've suffered qi deviation, so I slipped in to check."

"Two days?"

"Yes. You didn't know?"

"No, I knew."

That was a lie. I'd thought half a day had passed at most. Two whole days?

I looked toward the sunlit window and sighed inwardly.

"I appreciate you worrying about me, but next time, just leave me alone."

"Why?"

"Because seeing your face first thing when I woke up nearly gave me qi deviation."

"Isn't that a bit harsh?"

"Your face is harsh."

"Then I'll just stay nearby. You need someone to stand guard, don't you?"

"Don't stand guard, either."

"Why not?"

"Your snoring will give me qi deviation."

"…At this point, I'd be better off not being here at all. Keep this up and I might get fed up and head back to our family on my own."

I had just uncrossed my legs and was about to get up. Instead, I stared at Hyuk Mujin and his halfhearted attempt to threaten me.

"W-Why are you looking at me like that? Is there some rule that says I have to follow you around, Captain?"

Despite his words, he was watching me nervously. A laugh escaped me.

Hyuk Mujin had been hunching his shoulders, ready to dodge a punch that might come at any moment—or at least make it hurt less. Now he looked baffled.

"What's going on? Am I seeing things? Why are you acting like this all of a sudden, Captain?"

“Like what?”

“You’d normally have hit me at least twelve times by now, but you’re just smiling like some virtuous gentleman.”

I barely held back the laugh bubbling up inside me.

Then I kicked off the floor and shot forward like a flash of light.

Whoosh!

Hyuk Mujin instinctively tried to defend himself. In that split second, he moved with a speed and composure that made it hard to believe he was still only a First Rate martial artist.

Of course, against me, his defense had failed before it began.

“Hup.”

Realizing it was hopeless, Hyuk Mujin let out a strangled breath and squeezed his eyes shut. He was probably bracing for the hard blow that usually followed.

But for all his preparation, it never came.

Tap.

Instead of smacking him as I usually did, I lightly tapped the back of his head and clicked my tongue.

“You’ve been learning martial arts wrong all this time. Who told you to close your eyes?”

“…Huh?”

“Even if you’re getting hit, keep your eyes wide open. Even just keeping your eyes on your opponent puts you halfway there.”

Hyuk Mujin rubbed the back of his head, looking dazed, then blurted out, “Why are you acting like this all of a sudden?”

“Like what?”

“It’s strange. Normally…”

“So you want me to hit you like I usually do?”

Hyuk Mujin answered at once. “No. Not that.”

“Then shut up. I’m keeping you fit to fight.”

“Fit to fight?”

“Yeah. We’ll be fighting like hell soon. What good would hitting you on the back of the head do? If you caught a stray blade because of it, I’d end up having bad dreams for nothing.”

Hyuk Mujin grinned.

“Ohhh. So that’s what it is. You could be a little more honest, you know.”

“What?”

“I know all about it. When I said I might leave, it bothered you, didn’t it, Captain? Right?”

I started to answer, then just let out a quiet laugh.

“Yeah, you little shit. Must be nice to be so perceptive.”

“I knew it. I thought so. Even you need someone like me, your right-hand man, stuck to your side if you want to get anything done.”

“Right-hand man, my ass. You’re a little toe.”

“Come on, now. Calling myself your right-hand man is already a big concession on my part.”

“A concession?”

“Yes. Where else are you going to find a subordinate as loyal as me? I’m not your right hand—I’m your heart. Your heart.”

“Not a chance. You’ve got balls. How dare you call yourself my heart?”

“Then if I get them removed, do I qualify?”

Whack!

This time I put some force into it. For some reason, Hyuk Mujin groaned and clutched the back of his head, but his face lit up.

“Now that’s more like it.”

“…Huh?”

“It’s still a little weak, though. Hit me harder.”

What was with that creepy reaction?

Just as I began to question Hyuk Mujin’s tastes, he grinned and went on.

“It’s nothing, really. You’ve been so different from usual that I couldn’t help worrying.”

“…!”

“I know you’ve had a lot on your mind lately, but it’ll all work out. So do what you always do. Just like you always have.”

For a moment, I couldn’t speak.

At the same time, the truth I’d kept buried in my heart welled up and tickled the back of my throat.

But…

I can’t.

I couldn’t let a passing rush of emotion make me speak. To survive and win this enormous gamble, surrounded by monsters, I had to choose my words carefully.

In the end, after thinking it over, I managed only one question.

“Aren’t you scared?”

“Hm? Of what?”

“The situation we’re in. And whatever it is we’re about to face.”

Hyuk Mujin blinked at me for a long while, then answered, “What kind of question is that? Of course I’m scared.”

“You don’t act like it.”

“I’m used to being scared.”

“You’re used to it?”

“Yes. How do I put it? I’ve always been kind of a coward.”

Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head, looking embarrassed.

“When I was little, I was afraid my younger sibling would take all my parents’ love, so I cried every day. Then, when I got older and decided to become a martial artist, just holding a sword made me tremble. I thought I’d gotten better after joining the Jin Family of Taiyuan, but once I started following you around, Captain… I felt like I was going to piss myself every single day.”

That was the first I’d heard of it.

Thinking back, I’d never really asked Hyuk Mujin about his past.

I’d learned by chance that he was the eldest son of a large textile shop that had been in his family for three generations. It wasn’t as if I’d tried to find out.

Maybe that was why, instead of cutting off his long-winded story with a flick to the forehead as I normally would have, I found myself wanting to hear more.

“…Anyway, somehow I wound up stuck to your side.”

Hyuk Mujin finished with a shrug, then suddenly looked at me.

“This is all your fault, Captain.”

“Mine?”

“Yes. You’re like a ghost, always finding your way to places where people go to die. I got so much practice along the way that now I’m scared, but I’m not. You know what I mean?”

“So it was hard on you?”

“Hard? I thought I was going to die. But I never actually did. Or, to be precise, whenever I thought I was going to die, you saved me.”

Maybe not this time.

I swallowed the words that had been circling in my mouth.

Unaware of what I was thinking, Hyuk Mujin went on as if nothing were wrong.

“Maybe that’s why I’m not all that scared this time, either. Even when I heard what you told Comrade Hong and me recently, I felt pretty calm.”

“Because you figure I’ll save you again?”

“No.”

“No?”

“No. I just had a thought.”

For a moment, Hyuk Mujin looked straight at me and spoke.

“Oh, I thought, maybe this time I can be the one to save you, Captain.”

“…!”

“You said it was dangerous. That even you and Great Hero Jeok would have to risk your lives. That it was basically a gamble. Then couldn’t even someone as weak as me be useful this time?”

Hyuk Mujin added with a bright smile, “I’m still a First Rate nobody with a long way to go, but they say when you’re in trouble, even a cat’s paw is worth borrowing. Right?”

I didn’t answer.

No, I couldn’t.

It felt as if an invisible hand had closed around my throat, cutting off my breath. If I opened my mouth, I was afraid the truth might slip out before I could stop it.

So I looked at his smiling face in silence, then smiled back.

“Yeah. Now you’re finally going to be useful.”

“Ahem. This time, just trust me. I, Hyuk Mujin, am your right hand and your heart. I’m the Tenfold Man of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, aren’t I?”

Watching Hyuk Mujin thump his chest with exaggerated force, I let go of every worry still weighing on my mind.

And I was certain.

Every choice I made from here on out would be the right one.

“Remember what I told you two days ago?”

Hyuk Mujin’s smile faded, and he nodded.

“Which part…?”

“The Murim Alliance reinforcements.”

“Oh, of course. But when did you manage to get in touch with the Murim Alliance, Captain?”

“That’s not important, so forget it. I have a mission for you.”

“Just me?”

“No, everyone in the Fire Dragon Pavilion.”

“The entire pavilion means… you’re coming with us, Captain?”

“I’m not going. And neither is my Master. You’ll lead the rest of the group to the place I tell you and wait there.”

“Are we meeting the Murim Alliance reinforcements there?”

“Yeah. They’ll arrive within half a day at the earliest, and by tomorrow at the latest.”

Hyuk Mujin nodded as if he understood, then suddenly furrowed his brow.

“That’s longer than I expected. Leaving you here at a time like this is a bit… You’re not in your usual condition, either.”

“I’m not. So, are you afraid a Supreme Peak master who isn’t in his usual condition will keel over coughing blood at any moment?”

Hyuk Mujin grinned.

“Right. I was a crow-tit worrying about a Heavenly Eagle.”

“Usually, it’d be a stork you were worried about, not a Heavenly Eagle.”

“For the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, even a Heavenly Eagle isn’t enough. Anyway, is that the whole mission?”

“Yeah. Right now.”

I answered and took a neatly folded note from inside my robe, then handed it to him.

I’d prepared it two days ago, but until the last moment, I’d wavered over whether to take it out at all.

“Anyone besides me and my Master should be able to leave the imperial palace without much trouble. Once you’re sure no one’s following you, check the destination written there.”

“This is starting to feel less like the Fire Dragon Pavilion and more like the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.”

Hyuk Mujin carefully took the note and tucked it away. Then he clasped his hands in a salute.

“I’ll get going, then.”

“One last thing.”

“Yes?”

“Be careful. You and everyone else.”

Hyuk Mujin looked puzzled, then gave me a playful grin. He turned and disappeared.

Once his presence had faded completely, I slowly left the room and came face to face with the one person still there.

Whoosh.

A slow exhalation. Hong Jin looked at me through the cloudy smoke from his long-stemmed tobacco pipe, then murmured as if to himself, “Martial artist Hyuk seemed pretty busy.”

“He is. I gave him a mission.”

“It must be important, to send him off at a time like this.”

“Yes. It is.”

“I understand how you feel.”

Creak.

The old wooden chair groaned. Hong Jin rose with elegant poise and spoke through the haze of smoke.

“In a dangerous gamble where no one knows what will happen, you must want to save even one more person.”

“…!”

“So, Young Master Jin, are you ready?”

I nodded with a bitter smile.

“I’ve always been ready.”

A little while later, golden-armored guards lined up in front of the pavilion to escort us to the Grand Banquet Hall.

Chapter 899

Maybe it was because everything around me gleamed gold, but for a moment, I felt like the richest man in the world.

Sadly, reality was a long way from that.

Clank. Clank.

I might've been able to enjoy the feeling a little longer if not for those ominous metallic sounds.

But the Embroidered Uniform Guards surrounding Hong Jin and me as they marched along showed no sign of offering that kind of consideration.

To be fair, I'd be crazy to expect it.

A laugh slipped out before I could stop it. I felt a heated gaze from beside me. Hong Jin was staring at me in disbelief.

"What is it?"

"…You do know why I'm looking at you, right? I'm asking just in case."

"Hmm. Because I suddenly laughed at a time like this?"

"Thank goodness. I thought Young Master Jin had completely lost his mind."

"Don't worry. I'm holding on to my sanity."

It wasn't as if I could stand there grinning like a lunatic with my life hanging by a thread.

When you're backed up against a cliff, your mind actually grows calmer.

Everything else falls away, leaving only one word: survival.

Just like right now.

"I'll take your word for it. I have no choice."

Hong Jin muttered as if to himself, then slowly drew on his still-lit long-stemmed tobacco pipe.

The ember glowed red. He exhaled a plume of white smoke that drifted among the guards.

Smoking so boldly as he walked through the imperial palace, when his head might roll at any moment. I was privately impressed by Hong Jin's nerve when I noticed his eyelashes trembling and his face growing languid.

Then the smoke's distinctive scent reached me.

Now that I think about it, I always smell that when I'm near Hong Jin.

Normally, I'd thought nothing of it.

I wasn't some anti-smoking spokesperson. There was nothing strange about Hong Jin smoking a pipe, and no reason for me to stop him.

I'd simply assumed he was making up for what he lacked as a man by filling himself with nicotine.

But even so, I'd occasionally felt a strange sense of déjà vu.

Something about the smell was familiar, and I had no trouble remembering when I'd felt that way before.

Right. Immediately after I returned from my audience with the Emperor. That very day.

An idea flashed through my mind.

I watched Hong Jin slowly exhale smoke, then spoke up.

"It seems to taste better than I expected. The smell didn't appeal to me."

"What are you talking about? Oh, this?"

I gave a quiet nod. Hong Jin lightly waved the pipe in his hand.

"I wouldn't say it tastes good. It's just… a habit. A very bad one."

Of course smoking was bad for your health.

At least by modern standards.

But in this era, it wasn't exactly frowned upon.

This world had no place in any history passed down to the twenty-first century, but it was remarkably similar in many ways. The names of its regions, the clothes and food, even people's attitudes.

And by those standards, smoking wasn't considered a bad habit. If anything, the powerful, who indulged in every sort of pleasure, encouraged it. Tobacco leaves were expensive, though, so it was a luxury most commoners could hardly afford.

But Hong Jin is one of those powerful people, and even he calls it a bad habit?

Something clicked.

There was more to this. Something I hadn't figured out yet.

I held out my hand to Hong Jin.

"Can I try it?"

"Hmm? You want to smoke? This?"

"Yes. I thought I'd give it a try while I had the chance."

Our eyes met for an instant. Hong Jin's eyebrow twitched so slightly no one else could have noticed.

A sign that he'd understood exactly what I meant.

"How curious. The martial artists I know drink readily enough, but they rarely touch poppy."

"Poppy…?"

"It's the dried sap of the poppy. If you smoke it when your mind is troubled, sometimes it calms you down and makes you feel drowsy. It's often used to relieve pain, but it's highly addictive, so—"

Hong Jin's voice faded to a distant echo.

Only one word floated through my mind.

Opium!

I might've treated school lessons as a chance to catch up on sleep, but at least a little basic knowledge had stuck.

Especially since my world history teacher had a booming voice so passionate it could chase away the sleep that had already claimed me.

"Hey! Jin Taekyung!"

"Hrk. Huh?"

"You punk. What did the teacher just say? Don't roll your eyes around—tell me."

"Uh, well…"

"Right. You don't know. Of course you don't. You've slept through the entire third period back there. Is this a hotel or a school?"

"Oh, I remember now."

"What? You remember? Fine, let's hear what kind of creative bullshit you heard in your dream. What was it?"

"Hey, Jin Taekyung."

"…"

"No…?"

"No, that's right. It is. But… you really are a nutcase. The Opium War! I was talking about the Opium War. I swear, you're driving me crazy. Repeat after me. The Opium War!"

"What? The Youth Protection War?[3377]"

"Youth Protection… Hey, class president! Kim Minjeong!"

"Yes?"

"Call the cops right now. I'm going to beat this punk and get arrested for assaulting a student."

Fortunately, the police never came. After my teacher finished shouting at me, I was sentenced to copy out an entire section on the Opium War by hand.

That was how I'd managed to cram all sorts of trivial details into my thick skull—including the fact that the white-skinned island chinks had invaded the genuine mainland chinks.

And that opium came from a plant called the poppy.

So that's useful now.

I silently thanked my world history teacher, who'd been more passionate than anyone.

Thanks to him, I'd just learned something new.

Opium. No, that distinctive scent of poppy… I've smelled it before. Stronger than Hong Jin's.

[3377] Taekyung mishears *apyeon* (opium) as *acheong*, shorthand associated with Korea's law protecting children and youth from sexual crimes.

Just a few days ago.

I'd definitely felt that déjà vu. And only now did I realize what I'd overlooked at the time.

Listen carefully. Don't react.

Hong Jin kept walking as though nothing had happened. Barely moving my lips, I sent him a Sound Transmission.

If the Emperor smokes opium, why do you think he does it?

That day. That time. That moment.

The first person who'd stirred that sense of déjà vu was the man above all others—the one I'd met in Qianqing Palace.

"Hah."

With a ragged exhale, the man suddenly opened his eyes.

Faint torchlight flickered beyond the darkness. Long lengths of thin, colorful silk hung around him.

Where am I…

There was no mistaking the place. It was his bedchamber and his fortress, where he'd spent most of the past decade or so.

He lay there for a while, soaked in cold sweat as he caught his breath. Then he spoke.

"Is anyone there?"

The dry sound of his voice had barely faded when—

Rustle.

A breeze from somewhere stirred the silk curtains. A thread of Sound Transmission slipped between them and reached his ear.

—At your command.

The man said nothing for a while. He ran a hand over his face.

The deep furrows, too pronounced for his age, showed the marks of fatigue.

Though some time had passed since he'd awoken, his heart still pounded fiercely.

"It seems the sun has already set."

—It will soon be the hour of the Dog.[3378]

"The hour of the Dog.[3379] And the grand banquet?"

—The appointed hour of the Goat[3380] *has long since passed. The civil and military officials have all gathered.*

[3378] The hour of the Dog is a traditional two-hour period, approximately 7–9 p.m.
[3379] The hour of the Dog is a traditional two-hour period, approximately 7–9 p.m.
[3380] The hour of the Goat is a traditional two-hour period, approximately 1–3 p.m.

"Then is he there, too?"

He.

Hardly enough to identify one person among the many gathered for the grand banquet. Yet the shadow in the darkness answered without hesitation.

—*Yes.*

"…Unexpected. Martial artists may rush headlong into danger, but this is absurdly reckless."

The Emperor seemed to be speaking to himself, but he went on.

"Then again, someone had already foreseen it. His Master must have stayed, too."

—*He has also attended. However…*

"Go on."

—*The other martial artists, apart from those two, have left the imperial palace.*

"Left?"

—*Yes. They appeared to be moving with some purpose, but we could not follow them any farther.*

"You couldn't follow them?"

The man frowned, but the shadow's next words silenced him.

—*Yes. 'She' personally intervened and stopped us.*

"…I see."

—*If you command it, we can act at once.*

"No. No."

He shook his head and slowly rose from his bed.

The room was far too vast to be one person's bedchamber. Clad in sleeping robes embroidered with golden thread, he stood before a large mirror.

Rustle. Thud.

The soft silk slid over his skin and fell to the floor.

An ordinary person would have shivered at the sudden chill. But the man stood firm as an iron tower.

As he had when he led a great army to crush the rebels.

As he had that day, more than a decade ago.

But for all his enduring spirit, the figure reflected in the mirror bore little resemblance to the man he'd once been.

I've aged. Beyond recognition.

He felt no regret.

The path he'd walked was one someone had to take.

He'd simply been the one chosen.

He'd put on a dragon robe so dazzling no one dared raise their head to look at him, and been granted the title Son of Heaven.

He had no regrets.

Only the path ahead remained. Just one step left to take.

“It’s time for me to leave Qianqing Palace.”

At his words, the darkness where the shadow had melted stirred, and Qianqing Palace, silent as a grave, sprang to life.

No. They had been ready from the beginning.

Ready to kill and to die at the Emperor’s command.

And on the roof of Qianqing Palace, its pulse throbbing like a volcano on the verge of eruption, a woman gazed up at the cloudy sky.

“Will it rain again today?”

So Gyo stroked the weapons hanging at either side of her waist.

She had them back after a long time. They were cold as ice, while the qi within them boiled hot as fire.

The Grand Banquet Hall was unbelievably vast and impossibly quiet. Countless officials, high and low, had gathered, yet not one of them spoke.

For that moment, they were all blind, unable to see, and mute, unable to speak.

Those who already knew what was happening quietly reflected on the lives they’d led up to then. Those who didn’t know were frozen in place by the suffocating presence that had swallowed the Grand Banquet Hall.

Who would speak first?

Who would be the first to… draw a sword?

As the same thought passed through every mind—

“There he is.”

A voice broke the silence.

“Five hours late. Are you kidding me?”

Jin Taekyung’s gaze pierced the darkness beyond the flickering torches.

More precisely, it pierced the enormous golden procession approaching from beyond, like a dragon.

Chapter 900

Thud. Thud-thud.

The earth trembled. Blazing torches roused the night.

A thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards marched in formation beneath fluttering imperial banners. Behind them came countless eunuchs and palace maids.

At the center of the procession was an enormous, magnificent imperial carriage built for one person alone.

Boom!

At last, the thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards entered the Grand Banquet Hall and stamped their feet in unison.

The powerful wave of qi they unleashed shook the air and washed over everyone's skin.

"At last…"

Those who heard the voice slip from someone's lips suddenly wondered:

Who had said that?

Which side were they on, and what outcome were they waiting for?

But there was no time to think of an answer.

From the enormous procession that had come to a halt, someone slowly rode forward on a fine steed and let out a thunderous cry.

"The sovereign of the Great Nation, master of Heaven and Earth and all things beneath them, has deigned to appear in person! All civil and military officials, great and small, kneel and pay your respects to His Majesty the Emperor!"

Whoosh!

Not even the golden armor encasing his body or the helmet pulled low over his head could hide his truly overwhelming presence.

At the shout, infused with internal energy, from Baek Yeon—the Emperor's right hand in name and deed, and Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard—everyone in the Grand Banquet Hall rose and knelt.

Clatter.

There were hundreds of civil and military officials, and thousands of soldiers already standing guard all around them.

They moved as one, bowing their heads to the ruler of this vast continent.

Even if, for some of them, it was nothing more than an empty show of respect, the fuse that would bring this banquet to an end had not yet burned all the way down.

"Long live His Majesty the Emperor."

At Ma Sanbao's quiet murmur, everyone joined in.

"Long live His Majesty the Emperor! Long live! Long, long live!"

At the very end of that resounding cheer, the Emperor stepped down from his sedan chair and walked slowly through the human curtain of guards.

Step. Step.

His footsteps rang out with unusual clarity.

But with their heads bowed, they couldn't see the Emperor as he passed. Only after he had taken his place on the throne atop the lofty stairs could they straighten up and face him.

The ruler of all under Heaven, who had shut himself away in Qianqing Palace for years on end while attending to the affairs of state.

The Great Nation's fourth prince turned rebel, then rebel turned Emperor: a notorious unfilial wretch and butcher who had finally seized the throne.

And a man of tempestuous fortune, standing at the highest place beneath Heaven.

They were stunned.

"…!"

"…!"

In an instant, shock and disquiet swept across the Grand Banquet Hall like an invisible wave.

There was no trace of the Emperor's once-youthful, handsome appearance in the man who had emerged after his long seclusion.

But the Emperor paid it no mind.

He looked down haughtily at the countless gazes fixed on him.

Though he had aged beyond recognition, his eyes shone brighter than anyone else's in the hall as he surveyed the gathered officials, great and small, one by one.

The pillars that held up this vast empire. Its very heart.

Among them were generals who commanded armies, and old scholars whose backs were bent but whose eyes remained unbowed.

Ma Sanbao, the East Depot's de facto leader and the Emperor's greatest adversary, was there as well.

But the last place the Emperor's gaze fell was far off at the end of the hall, where a young man watched him in silence.

Jin Taekyung.

Their eyes met across the hall.

The Emperor looked at Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung looked at the Emperor.

They stared at each other for a while without saying a word. At last, the Emperor's firmly closed lips parted.

"Begin."

Perhaps it wasn't just a few people who imagined it.

Boom. Boom. Bwoom!

The drums heralding the start of the grand banquet sounded like war drums announcing the opening of a battle.

The atmosphere, frozen like a glacier, began to thaw little by little when musicians and dancers entered with an astonishing spread of delicacies and began to perform.

The melody stirred the heart, and sleeves fluttered in time with the music.

On top of that, the imperial chefs had displayed all their skill, and the finest wines were served without limit.

Perhaps it was only natural that those who'd had a drink to settle their nerves began to relax a little.

"Whew. I can finally breathe."

"Indeed. I really thought something was about to happen…"

"Shut your mouth. You want to say the wrong thing and invite needless suspicion?"

"M-My apologies, sir."

"If I hear you say something that disrespectful again, I won't let it pass."

The middle-aged man reprimanded the young official beside him in a carefully lowered voice, then swept a sharp gaze around them.

He seemed worried someone might have overheard.

I casually picked up a bite of food from the appetizer in front of me.

The next moment, I felt the middle-aged man across from me fixing me with an unusually persistent stare.

The young official's voice reached my ears, too.

"S-Sir. I did misspeak, but no one could've heard me. The Embroidered Uniform Guards are far away, too."

He wasn't wrong.

The hall being used for today's grand banquet was large enough to train thousands of soldiers at once. The officials, seated at regular intervals, were quite far apart.

And though every Embroidered Uniform Guard was an exceptional master, only a few, including their commander, Baek Yeon, remained by the Emperor's side.

The rest were far away, holding their assigned positions.

But even after hearing the young official, the middle-aged man kept watching me closely for a while before asking,

"Do you know anything about that man?"

"Pardon? W-Well, I've heard in passing that he's a ruffian from the martial world."

"Is that all?"

“I’m not sure what you mean…”

“Tsk. You really don’t think, do you? Be grateful that your father and I have a connection. Otherwise, you wouldn’t have made it this far.”

The middle-aged man clicked his tongue and continued in the same low whisper.

“How could some ruffian attend a banquet like this? He’s Prince Shangshan’s bodyguard and guest, brought here by His Highness. He’s also the third son of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, whose influence has recently spread all the way south of the Yangtze.”

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan. The Jin Family of Taiyuan… Do you mean the family that runs the Jin Family Trading Company and the Jin Family Escort Bureau?”

“That’s right. And that Jin Family of Taiyuan is based in Shanxi, Prince Shangshan’s fief.”

“Ah.”

The young official let out a faint exclamation.

“A family of that standing must wield considerable influence in Shanxi Province.”

“With Prince Shangshan’s protection, how could it be otherwise? Martial artists who defy the Great Nation’s solemn laws have no business wielding that kind of power… but apparently they rule as de facto overlords across Shanxi Province.”

“Is that why you’re paying attention to him, sir? Because he’s the son of a martial arts family?”

“It’s more than that.”

“Then…”

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. That’s his sobriquet. A tremendous master, barely in his twenties, who’s already accomplished countless feats of arms. There’s no one in the martial world who hasn’t heard of him.”

“You’ve done your homework.”

“There was no need to look into it in detail. Even among the people of the Imperial Capital, there are countless who know of Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung…”

The middle-aged man, who hadn’t taken his eyes off me as he spoke, suddenly frowned.

“Did you just speak casually to me?”

But the young official didn’t answer.

Normally, he would’ve scrambled to make excuses. Now his face had gone white as he stared at someone standing behind him and the middle-aged man.

One second.

Two seconds.

Three.

After a silence in which the world seemed to stop, the middle-aged man slowly turned to follow the young official's gaze.

Then he froze like a statue.

"Y-Your Majesty…!"

It wasn't just my imagination: the words, forced from deep in his lungs, sounded like a scream.

The Emperor.

The absolute ruler called the Son of Heaven, a descendant of Heaven, looked down at the two men without a word.

As if considering how to kill them.

Perhaps he seemed all the more likely to do just that because Baek Yeon stood tall behind him—the very man who had led the purge of tens of thousands of "traitors" more than a decade ago.

"Y-Your Majesty. Please…"

Flap.

The Emperor made a small gesture, and the man's voice cut off.

That was right. This arrogant and cruel absolute ruler still hadn't spoken.

And he would allow no one to speak before him.

By now, the Grand Banquet Hall had fallen into deathly silence. The Emperor abruptly turned his head and looked at me.

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"…!"

"…!"

I could feel it.

The air trembling.

Countless gazes piercing me from head to toe.

The Emperor had spoken first to me, the only outsider among the high officials who supported the empire and the gathered civil and military officials.

And he'd walked all the way to my lowly seat at the far end of the hall, well away from his throne, to do it.

"I ask you: what should I do with these people?"

If this had happened a few days ago, I would've been shocked.

Why the fuck is this crazy bastard pulling this shit out of nowhere? I probably would've thought something like that—and started to feel like I needed to piss.

But not today.

Yeah. No.

I'd already stepped into a gamble where everyone had staked their lives.

Perhaps all of this had been inevitable from the moment I entered the tiger's den that was the imperial palace.

The time had come.

The die had been cast. Now it was time to see how it landed.

"Well, before I answer, would it be all right if I had a drink?"

Whoosh.

The air trembled again.

No, *trembled* might not be quite the word.

If the earlier disturbance had been a ripple from a stone dropped into a lake, this was a triangular wave—a disaster.

Everyone in the Grand Banquet Hall gaped as that wave swept over them in an instant. I looked at the Emperor, who gave a small nod, and spoke.

"Then I'll take that as permission."

Glug.

Instead of answering, I tossed back the wine already poured into my cup. Cries of shock and angry shouts erupted from every direction.

The wave that hadn't seemed real even when they'd seen and heard it for themselves had finally hit them.

"What a lunatic!"

"H-How dare that man…!"

"How can there be such a lawless man in this world?"

"Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, what are you doing? Why haven't you cut down that high traitor yet?"

"Your Majesty! Punish that outrageous ruffian at once for insulting Your Majesty and the imperial household!"

"Please punish him!"

Listen to that decibel level.

They say the more people curse you, the longer you live. If this raucous enthusiasm had lasted another fifteen minutes, my sobriquet might've become Three Thousand Jiazi[3381] instead of Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

Beheading was the basic option, and they kept piling on extras: cut off my balls, torture me slowly, then tear me limb from limb by quartering.

…No, I mean, the balls are a bit much.

Was that guy from the Sichuan Tang Clan or something?

I took a good look at the face of the man who'd proposed castrating me, then put down my cup.

Then I looked at the Emperor and spoke.

[3381] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year calendrical cycle. Three thousand jiazi would be 180,000 years.

“Kill them if you want, or spare them if you want. Isn’t that what Your Majesty does best?”

Well.

I was starting to feel like I needed to piss.

Chapter 901

Silence.

Perfect silence settled over the Grand Banquet Hall. Not even the faintest breath could be heard.

Along with it came countless eyes, wide with shock, all fixed on one person.

What… did he just say?

What on earth did I just hear?

Everyone wondered the same thing. As they stared at the young man, they recalled the words that had just rung through the hall.

> “Kill them if you want, or spare them if you want. Isn’t that what Your Majesty does best?”

Everyone had heard him clearly.

They doubted their memories once, twice, ten times, but reality refused to change. Forgetting all about decorum, people gaped at him, barely managing to swallow the curses on the tips of their tongues.

That crazy bastard.

Even *crazy bastard* fell far short of describing what Jin Taekyung had done.

He had provoked the Emperor to his face.

Mocked him.

The Emperor, of all people.

The usurper who had cut down tens of thousands of political enemies like a farmer reaping a harvest, then built the strongest centralized regime since Taizu, founder of the Great Nation.

He’s insane. Completely insane.

The officials in the lowest seats, their ranks too low to sit anywhere else, and even the high-ranking ministers at the heart of the political world all turned deathly pale and pressed their lips together.

Something had happened that could never be allowed to happen.

Calling it treason would hardly be a stretch. What came next was obvious.

They would die. Die, and die again.

Jin Taekyung and his entire family, along with everyone connected to them, would vanish like dew on the execution ground.

And there was every chance the Embroidered Uniform Guard’s death list would include several people with no connection to any of it.

The late Emperor’s loyal subjects.

It wasn't hard to predict that some of those who considered Prince Shangshan the rightful heir would become targets.

Evidence? Justification?

Neither mattered.

Both could be manufactured.

Once the torture instruments tore through their flesh and muscle, even the most loyal subject would writhe in pain and beg for death.

The imperial torturers knew how to turn lies into truth and truth into lies. That work had once belonged to the East Depot, but it had long since passed to the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

In other words, the sword was in one man's hands alone.

The Emperor's.

One order from him, and it would all be over.

Jin Taekyung had already given him grounds for punishment. No one could say whom the Emperor's blade might cut down.

Even if the final target were Prince Shangshan.

How could he do something this absurd? What on earth is he thinking…?

Grit.

Some of the assembled officials clenched their teeth to hold back groans.

Each of them either supported Prince Shangshan in secret or had signed the pledge and dreamed of a restoration. To them, the whole situation felt like a terrible calamity.

Jin Taekyung had entered the imperial court as Prince Shangshan's guest. The prince wouldn't be able to escape responsibility, either.

Heh… So Heaven's Mandate is leaving the Great Nation.

Those who knew nothing of the restoration lamented the heavens.

The plan's gone off course, but we have no choice. We may have to act right now…

Those who had signed the pledge steeled themselves and watched Ma Sanbao, their faces rigid. The moment he gave the order, they would move.

But then—

"Yes. You are right."

The Emperor broke the long silence, plunging everyone into shock once more.

"And a man who wishes to become a sage king does not punish those who speak the truth."

"…!"

"…!"

"Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Standing at the center of the silence, the Emperor continued evenly.

“In the name of the Son of Heaven, I forgive the disrespect you have shown me.”

Forgive.

He’d said he forgave him.

The very man who had ruthlessly slaughtered tens of thousands.

The cruel Emperor who had launched a rebellion and a great purge.

Everyone who had been at a loss for words stared blankly at the back of the absolute ruler—everyone except one person.

Reading the sliver of emotion the Emperor hadn’t quite managed to hide from his face, Jin Taekyung muttered to himself.

So that’s how you’re playing it.

Provoking the Emperor had been a gamble with his life. If it failed, it could throw every plan the restoration army had made into disarray.

That’s why it had to be now.

And the gamble had paid off.

He had gained a crucial key. The Emperor’s answer had also settled a question he’d hardly dared ask himself.

Forgiveness, after that? It makes no sense.

Except in one case.

Jin Taekyung quietly swallowed the rest of his thought.

The scattered pieces of the puzzle began to fall into place. His head, which had felt ready to burst moments ago, gradually cleared. As his mind settled, a new path came into view.

But he still didn’t have every answer.

But why on earth…?

He started to send the Emperor a Sound Transmission.

Or rather, he would have, if someone hadn’t arrived just then.

“How heartening to hear that Your Majesty wishes to become such a merciful sage king.”

“…!”

Jin Taekyung reacted a little faster than the Emperor. Baek Yeon reacted faster than Taekyung.

Somewhere only five *jang*[3382] away, an old man with pale skin appeared without a sound. In a hoarse, aged voice, he continued, cupping his hands toward the Emperor.

“The late Emperor would be pleased as well. Would he not?”

Rustle.

The old man slowly raised his head, setting his long white hair swaying.

[3382] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Five *jang* is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

The Emperor's stiff face was reflected in gray eyes that held the weight of many years. A dry voice emerged between cracked lips.

"Your servant Wei Zhong, Seal-Holding Eunuch of the East Depot, pays his respects to Your Majesty."

The moment I saw Wei Zhong, I reflexively thought of an old fantasy movie I'd watched as a kid.

A vast fantasy world. A party of heroes from different races setting out to destroy a certain necklace that was the source of the Demon King's power.

And one of its central characters: an old mage.

"…Gandalf?"

The white hair that looked long enough to reach his knees. The gray eyes.

Strictly speaking, he looked more like *a very sick Gandalf*, but I couldn't deny the resemblance.

The slight problem was that I'd said it aloud without realizing.

Ah.

I shut my mouth as soon as I caught myself, but it was too late. Everyone who'd briefly looked elsewhere had turned back to me, including the Emperor.

And the very sick Gandalf. Wei Zhong.

"You must be the very man I've heard so much about."

What was I supposed to say to that?

I thought it over for a moment, then gave a small nod instead. Wei Zhong let out a snort and turned back toward the Emperor.

"A truly rude man. Wouldn't you agree, Your Majesty?"

The Emperor didn't answer.

He gazed at Wei Zhong with eyes sunk deep in thought, and only spoke once the air around them had grown so cold it seemed frozen.

"I was about to send someone for you, since you were nowhere to be seen… It's been a long time, Cang Gong. Have you been well?"

"After a rather long period of recuperation, I've finally recovered enough to move about. I owe it all to Your Majesty's grace."

"My grace? Are you certain?"

"Even the finest physicians couldn't guarantee I would live. Seeing how much I've recovered, surely it must be Heaven's will. And so I owe it all to Your Majesty, the Son of Heaven."

"That's unfortunate. If you'd had the decoction made as the imperial physician I sent advised, you might have overcome your illness sooner."

"I beg your forgiveness. However, I feared my old body couldn't withstand the medicine prepared by the imperial physicians, so I had no choice but to recuperate instead. But…"

Concern suddenly clouded Wei Zhong's face as he studied the Emperor.

"Perhaps it has simply been too long since I last saw you, but Your Majesty does not look well. Has illness taken hold of your august person?"

"…!"

A chill passed through the Emperor's eyes, already hard with displeasure.

"There's no need to worry. It isn't as bad as you fear."

"Then I'm greatly relieved. Now that you've become a sage king who shows such mercy, you must rule the realm for ten thousand years—ten thousand times ten thousand years."

I could feel it.

The invisible blades the Emperor and Cang Gong kept trading.

And the immense qi now pouring from the Emperor.

Rrrrmmm.

The air around us churned. Several nearby officials went pale and trembled as though seized by a chill.

His title overshadowed it, but the Emperor was a Supreme Peak master who had entered the realm of the superhuman.

But…

Cang Gong is different. That man is something else.

I'd known it from the moment he appeared.

That pale old man who looked like Gandalf was a greater master than anyone else here.

Even Baek Yeon.

In a fight between Supreme Peak masters, life and death could be decided in an instant.

The fact that Cang Gong had come within five *jang*[3383] of us without me sensing him meant he'd all but seized the initiative.

Now I see why Ma Sanbao was so confident.

From what I could sense, Cang Gong and So Gyo were evenly matched. If Jeok Cheongang and the other fighters who hadn't yet reached the Grand Banquet Hall joined the restoration army, they could bring down So Gyo with ease.

Though So Gyo herself had yet to appear.

She's probably guarding Prince Shangshan somewhere else.

[3383] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Five *jang* is about 15.2 m (49.7 ft).

The prince was a crucial key. Neither the restoration army nor the Emperor could afford to let him fall into the enemy's hands.

Apparently, I wasn't the only one thinking about him.

"Your Majesty. Perhaps the recent storms have made the weather unusually chilly today. Might Your Majesty show some mercy for the sake of those poor officials, who are trembling over there?"

Cang Gong indicated the shivering officials. His manner was respectful and relaxed, but there was a barb in his words. Then he spoke again, as though a thought had just occurred to him.

"By the way, why are Prince Shangshan and the pregnant Consort nowhere to be seen? As members of the imperial family, surely they ought to grace this occasion alongside Your Majesty—"

"Shut your mouth, Wei Zhong."

Baek Yeon cut him off, his voice hard. He was about to step forward when—

"Enough."

The Emperor raised a hand to stop him and fixed Wei Zhong with a cold stare.

"You needn't concern yourself, Cang Gong. Both of them are already on their way."

"I'm deeply grateful for Your Majesty's grace. At last, I'll meet the heir who will one day rule this vast Great Nation."

"Yes. You will."

Neither man said anything more.

Nor did either bother to ask the other which heir he truly had in mind, or whom the other considered the heir.

They would wait for the banquet to reach its height. For the fuse to burn all the way down.

And so would I.

"Excuse me. It looks like you two are about done talking. Could I say something, if you don't mind?"

The Emperor answered.

"What is it?"

"Nothing much. It looks like you're heading up to the seats of honor, so I was hoping I could move too. Preferably next to Cang Gong."

"…You want to change seats?"

The officials, who had been frozen in place, all turned to glare at me as though they wanted to tear me apart. While the Emperor searched for words, Cang Gong spoke instead.

"Is there… some particular reason?"

I gave him my most confident, dashing look.

"The seats up there seem to get more side dishes."

Of course, I didn’t look particularly dashing.

Chapter 902

This might have been a first in the history of the Great Nation.

A ruffian from the martial world who held no official post and didn't even carry an identity token, seated among the court's high officials at a grand banquet presided over by the Emperor himself.

The first, and probably the last.

Even considering the short history of the Great Nation, which had only lasted three generations so far, it was a feat unlikely ever to be repeated.

Yet almost no one spoke up against this insult to the imperial family's dignity.

Not unless they were among the handful of ministers with unwavering convictions and courage.

"Your Majesty! Forgive my boldness, but seating that man so close to you—"

"It is the imperial decree."

"…A wise decision indeed!"

As it turned out, even conviction and courage crumbled like a sandcastle struck by a wave when faced with the Emperor.

Especially when that Emperor's hobby—and specialty—was purging people.

Thanks to him, I took my seat before an even more lavish spread without further trouble.

Smack. Smack-smack. Slurp.

As I inhaled one dish after another, the people around me stared, their eyes twitching at every sound.

When I showed off the godlike noodle-slurping technique I'd honed on ramen, groans broke out all around.

"Good heavens."

"Have you ever seen such a low-class bastard…?"

"That's enough to kill what little appetite I had. Look—even Cang Gong hasn't touched his food."

At that last remark, I glanced over. Cang Gong was watching me steadily with his gray eyes.

Hmm. Was that too much?

"Pay no mind to them. Keep eating. Is it really that good?"

At Cang Gong's calm question, I answered.

"Definithely delishious."

"I see. But perhaps you should finish what's in your mouth first."

"Oh."

I swallowed the mouthful crammed into my cheeks, then spoke again.

“It’s definitely good. There are plenty of side dishes, too.”

Cang Gong nodded.

“I understood you the first time. My hearing isn’t that bad. Besides, the imperial chefs have long been renowned for their cooking.”

“Then why aren’t you eating?”

“I don’t have much of an appetite. It’s been that way for some time.”

“Hmm. Well, that’s a relief. I thought I’d put you off your food.”

“Don’t worry about that. I’ve been this way since I was young. Though it is a little disappointing that even the finest, rarest delicacies feel like grains of sand in my mouth now.”

Cang Gong looked away from me and down at the table before him, his face expressionless.

It held enough food to make its legs bow under the weight, yet his hands rested neatly on his knees and never moved toward it.

Hands with no color in them—white, or rather, pale as a corpse’s.

I studied him. Despite sitting right beside me, he barely gave off any sense of presence. Then I quietly moved my lips.

“When are we going to start?”

At that moment—

Vrrrm.

A subtle, chilling qi sealed off the space around us. Anyone who wasn’t paying close attention would never have noticed it.

Remarkable.

Cang Gong had shut out sound with a flawless barrier of internal energy. He spoke.

“I’ll give the signal.”

“I think now would be the perfect time.”

“As long as that woman called So Gyo remains by Prince Shangshan’s side, we can’t act rashly. Even if we take the Emperor’s head, everything will be for nothing if we can’t secure His Highness.”

“That’s true.”

“Besides, your master is still waiting outside the banquet hall. The Fire King is essential if we’re to defeat So Gyo.”

“I don’t know about that. I’d say you’re every bit as formidable a master as my teacher.”

“This old man was able to overcome a grave Internal Injury and attend today thanks to the good fortune of gaining insight during my recovery. The more important the matter, the more carefully it must be handled, don’t you think?”

Yeah, that made sense.

I nodded naturally and resumed moving the chopsticks I’d set down for a moment.

Cang Gong watched me as if I were some strange creature, then spoke.

“You look like you haven’t eaten in days.”

“You’ve got that right. I’ve barely eaten anything for two days.”

“A master of your caliber should be able to endure a little hunger.”

“Why should I have to? I believe in eating a hearty meal before a fight.”

“Are you nervous?”

“I am. My stomach is.”

“You really do take after your master. It takes quite a nerve to sit here eating like this, just as I’d heard.”

“Did you hear anything else about me?”

“That your martial arts are unparalleled for someone your age, and that you’re resourceful and tenacious enough to survive any crisis.”

“Sounds about right.”

“That was the abbreviated version. The East Depot has eyes and ears throughout the land, and their reports never fail to surprise me. One of the most recent was particularly unexpected.”

“May I ask what it was? What could surprise even Cang Gong?”

“The Murim Alliance reinforcements.”

“Ah.”

“I truly didn’t expect that. I thought the Murim Alliance had already deployed most of its forces throughout the land to deal with sudden attacks by Dark Heaven, which could appear anywhere at any time.”

Instead of answering, I lifted my cup and took a drink. The fragrant aroma of a truly fine liquor filled my mouth, and it went down smoothly.

Any intoxication that should have followed vanished without a trace when it met my Scorching Yang Qi.

“I hear Dark Heaven uses the strangest supernatural powers. Did the Alliance really have enough strength left to form a reserve force?”

“If they didn’t, the reinforcements wouldn’t be coming.”

“They’re coming because the Alliance had the strength to spare… Yes, I suppose so.”

Cang Gong was gazing steadily at me with his gray eyes when—

“Enough.”

The Emperor’s resonant voice rang out, and in the same instant, the beautiful music that had filled the grand banquet hall vanished as if it had been washed away.

Those who had been whispering to one another, those who had been drinking with solemn faces—even the musicians and dancers forcing themselves to perform in that atmosphere—all fell silent.

Everyone stopped moving and turned toward the Emperor, following his voice and gaze.

"My heir approaches. He shall inherit this continent and the Great Nation that will endure for the next thousand years. Receive him with all due ceremony."

"…!"

"…!"

An unmistakable declaration of his heir.

Everyone had expected it, yet some part of them had thought it couldn't possibly happen. Now that the moment had arrived, shock swept through the banquet hall.

But while their minds raced, their bodies were already bending in the prescribed bows toward a newly arrived eight-horse carriage.

Boom. Boom-boom. Boom-boom-boom!

The drummer's vigorous beat made the air shudder. As anticipation quietly built, the carriage door opened and someone stepped out.

Swish.

The hem of a splendid red palace gown brushed the ground. The woman stepped lightly onto the back of a palace attendant prostrated before the carriage and descended. Her alluring beauty drew a low gasp from somewhere in the hall.

"Good heavens."

"It can't be…"

It was tactless, but I understood.

The woman was beautiful enough to topple a kingdom.

No wonder the City Lord of Sichuan Province fell so hard for her.

I thought to myself as I looked at the woman—or rather, Aehyang.

Until only a few months ago, she had been the City Lord of Sichuan Province's favored concubine. Now she walked beneath the Embroidered Uniform Guard's close protection, stroking her belly with an uneasy look on her face.

And while everyone's eyes followed her, I saw someone else emerge from the still-open carriage door.

A face that still belonged to a child.

Yet his expression and stride were bolder than those of any young man.

Prince Shangshan, Zhu Bao.

As I watched Prince Shangshan stride up the long staircase, I wondered what to say.

How should I greet the young prince after several days apart?

I didn't have to think for long.

“Have you been well?”

My Sound Transmission crossed the space between us, and Prince Shangshan stopped in his tracks. I let out a quiet laugh to myself and moved my lips again.

“Are you still keeping the item I entrusted to you safe?”

After a brief pause, he started walking again. Prince Shangshan didn’t look my way. Instead, he flicked the sleeve covering the back of his hand.

For a moment, I caught sight of a dark, dull ring.

I nodded at the sight of the Myriad-Poison Ring, and Cang Gong suddenly spoke.

“Good. It seems His Highness is still keeping it safe.”

I wasn’t surprised. Cang Gong had reached a level even I couldn’t fathom. I’d figured he could listen in on a Sound Transmission.

“He does. I was worried he might lose it, so that’s a relief.”

I answered calmly without even turning my head. I could feel Cang Gong watching me, but his gaze soon shifted to someone else.

So Gyo.

I saw her.

There she was, following quietly behind Prince Shangshan.

In place of her flexible sword, she wore two weapons at her waist, each curving like a saber. So Gyo looked straight at me and gave me a faint smile.

“Did you see that?” Cang Gong asked.

At Cang Gong’s question, I answered calmly.

“I did.”

“She was smiling at you.”

“Did she? I thought she was smiling at you.”

“You’re mistaken. That look just now… it was directed straight at you.”

“As Eunuch Ma probably told you, we’ve met before.”

“Is that the only reason?”

“What other reason could there be?”

“A thousand years! A thousand years! A thousand thousand years!”[3384]

The civil and military officials of the court, along with nearly two thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards, roared their cheers toward the heir of the Great Nation, shaking the whole place.

Whether they were merely going along with the occasion or were genuinely celebrating it, they all chanted with one voice. At the center of that immense cheer stood the Emperor, Aehyang, and finally, Prince Shangshan.

Beside me sat the only person who wasn’t joining in.

[3384] *Cheonse*, “a thousand years,” is a traditional court acclamation wishing a royal figure long life. *Cheoncheonse*, “a thousand thousand years,” intensifies the wish.

“I find myself wondering what you think,” Cang Gong said.

He continued without waiting for an answer.

“Why did the Emperor forgive you, despite your unforgivable disrespect? It was the perfect chance to remove Prince Shangshan while gaining both a pretext and a practical advantage.”

“I don’t know. I’m a pretty simple guy.”

“Simple? Then was that stunt you pulled, suddenly and without any plan, just a result of your personality?”

“Maybe it was. Maybe it wasn’t.”

“Tell me more.”

“To hell with the grand plan. A lot of lives were at stake, and there was one thing I had to make sure of.”

Cang Gong was no longer looking toward the throne where the Emperor stood. Nor was he bowing to it. He sat upright and fixed his gray eyes on me.

“So, have you finished checking?”

“Yes.”

“What did you conclude?”

“No matter how I looked at it, there was only one answer.”

I held Cang Gong’s gaze, my eyes burning, and spoke quietly.

“The Emperor doesn’t want Prince Shangshan put in danger.”

“…!”

Chapter 903

Some mysteries have no answer, no matter how long you think about them. When that happens, there's only one thing left to try.

Turn everything upside down.

Forget all the circumstances and clues you've gathered so far, and start over from the beginning. That's the last resort.

Like retracing your steps to find something precious you don't remember dropping, I went back to the starting point and reconsidered every detail, large and small.

At last, I arrived at a hypothesis.

"The Emperor doesn't want Prince Shangshan put in danger."

"…!"

A faint ripple passed through Cang Gong's gray eyes.

It appeared and vanished in less time than it took to blink, but I'd been watching his every tiny movement too closely to miss it.

So it was true.

The realization struck me, sending a jolt down my spine.

The crowd's tremendous cheering still hadn't died down when Cang Gong, who had been gazing steadily at me, spoke.

"When did it start?"

Anyone else might have struggled to understand the question without context. I knew at once what he meant.

When had I started suspecting them?

"So Gyo."

Yes. That was exactly when.

The day she let me go, despite having every advantage. She couldn't possibly have failed to stop me.

Nothing I knew, no clue I could find, fully explained her strange behavior. It had stayed with me like a fishbone caught in my throat.

"So Gyo…"

Cang Gong gave a small nod at my brief answer.

"Yes, I suppose it would be. She was the only flaw in this grand scheme. Had I known it would come to this, I should have eliminated that mysterious woman long ago. Even if it meant an all-out war with the Emperor."

What?

I swallowed the question before it could burst out, but I couldn't hide my momentary shock.

Even Cang Gong doesn't know who So Gyo is?

Cang Gong caught the confusion that had appeared on my face and gave a low laugh.

"From the looks of it, you don't know who she is either. You don't even know whether she's an ally or an enemy."

"…!"

"Strange. Very strange. Until just now, I suspected she might be a Murim Alliance spy, but… now I haven't the faintest idea. Even if she were a master secretly trained by the imperial family, she couldn't have escaped my notice."

This time, setting aside the situation I was in, I couldn't help sharing Cang Gong's bewilderment.

Then who is So Gyo?

If she'd belonged to the Murim Alliance, she would have told me the whole truth before things got to this point. And if she were a master of Dark Heaven or the imperial family, Cang Gong would have known.

But So Gyo was different.

From what I'd been able to determine, she was a third party. Someone who belonged to neither side.

Who the hell is she?

Who was So Gyo? What expression was she wearing as she watched us right now? What was she thinking?

And…

Is she an enemy or an ally?

I fought the urge to look toward So Gyo, who should have been standing at the top of the stairs in the distance.

Cang Gong and I were only a few steps apart. Taking my eyes off him for even a moment would be suicide.

Of course, the only reason I could afford to stand here provoking him was that I was certain he couldn't kill me yet.

"You have a fine look in your eyes. Fighting spirit spilling over. But why would that person take an interest in you?"

That person.

There was no mistaking the fear and reverence in Cang Gong's voice as he spoke of someone who wasn't here.

The Blood Lord, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had all felt the same way.

Dark Heaven existed because it had a heaven of its own: the Lord of Heaven.

"Tell me. As the person concerned, you might know why that person is searching for you so relentlessly. Is it because you've achieved something unprecedented at

such a young age? Or is it because of some other worth only that person can recognize?”

His gray eyes, so like a dead man’s, glimmered faintly.

A chill came with that gaze, subtle and terrifying, unlike anything I’d ever felt.

Hissss.

I’d stake my life on it: even the Yin-Cold Qi of the Great Snow Fiend, who’d cornered me in Nanman, hadn’t been this intense.

No. This is different from Yin-Cold Qi.

Something more primal and pure.

A different kind of power, one I’d never heard of or experienced.

But I overcame my instinctive fear. Enduring the chill seeping into my bones, I answered.

“Why the hell are you asking me, you ball-less bastard?”

“…!”

Cang Gong stared at me, eyes wide, then smiled faintly.

“Yes, of course you wouldn’t know. How could someone like you presume to fathom that person’s intentions—”

“Yeah. I can look all I want, but I still can’t find your balls.”

“Choose your words carefully. No matter how generously that person has blessed me…”

“Yeah. I could search the whole ocean and still not find your testicles.”

“…”

“I chose my words carefully. What’s the problem?”

His faint smile was long gone. Amid the people’s continued cheering, Cang Gong’s tightly shut, pale lips parted.

“What do you think? Surely that person would understand if I merely pulled out your tongue.”

“Sure. The Lord of Heaven might. You’re the one among his followers he worries about most, seeing as you haven’t got any balls. His sore ball—no, his sore finger.”

I nodded in agreement and pointed over Cang Gong’s shoulder.

“But that guy won’t understand.”

In the slowed-down flow of time, everything happened at once.

Cang Gong turned his head to look behind him. I thrust a fist wreathed in flame at him. And a solid palm shot forward like a flash of light, as if reversing time all by itself, intercepting my fist before it could reach anyone.

BOOM!

A roar like the sky splitting open brought time rushing back to normal. At the same instant, a powerful shock wave shook the grand banquet hall.

Crack! Rrrrmm!

The ground shuddered as though an earthquake had struck.

Screams and shouts erupted on all sides.

Amid the sudden chaos, a pair of gleaming white eyes fixed on me.

“Was that all?”

Crack.

His voice was calm, but the immense force squeezing my fist was anything but.

An unknown, ice-cold energy filled his palm, suppressing the flames in mine and snuffing them out.

“Such a shallow trick. I’m disappointed.”

Crunch. Crunch.

Agonizing pain shot through my captured fist.

If my muscles and bones hadn’t surpassed the limits of an ordinary human, they would already have been ground to dust.

But I’d endured this much pain more times than I cared to count. And I’d never expected that surprise attack to bring him down.

I’d only needed a signal flare to let everyone know what was happening.

“I’m a little hurt that you think it was just a shallow trick.”

What?

“I don’t know if you’ve heard of magic, but I’m about to show you some. Watch closely.”

“What are you—”

The moment Cang Gong frowned—

BOOOOM!

Blinding flames swallowed the darkness, and the rock walls that ringed the grand banquet hall like towering ramparts burst apart.

From the place Cang Gong had glanced toward moments earlier, a figure strode out.

“I’ll give you my first and last warning.”

The flames dancing in that damn monk’s eyes looked anything but Buddhist. He swept his gaze across the hall and went on.

“Only step forward if you want your flesh and bones to melt.”

“…!”

Recognition darkened Cang Gong’s eyes. I smiled.

“Accio,[3385] Fire King.”

At the same time, I thrust out my still-free hand toward his chest. He faltered for an instant.

The Flame Divine Palm, at nine-tenths mastery.

[3385] *Accio* is a summoning spell in the *Harry Potter* series.

BOOOOM!

"Huh?"

The young man stopped abruptly and looked back.

Seeing him stare down the road they'd traveled, his brow furrowed, the burly man ahead of him asked, "Hyukmu. What's wrong?"

"No, it's just…"

Hyuk Mujin trailed off and clicked his tongue.

"I thought I heard something."

Taishan raised an eyebrow. "A sound? An enemy?"

"I don't know. Maybe I imagined it."

"Then no. That sound Hyukmu heard—Taishan didn't hear it."

"But I'm telling you, I'm sure I heard something."

"Hyukmu. Your martial arts are weak. Taishan could turn you into finely minced five-spice pork if he wanted."

"…Hey, what the hell? Are you looking down on me?"

"Mm. Honestly, a little."

"…"

"Hyukmu. We can't stop. We have to go. Everyone's waiting."

Hyuk Mujin swallowed his flare of anger and let out a long sigh.

"Yeah, I'm going. I'm going."

But despite his answer, his steps didn't come as easily as before.

The road behind him and the walls of the Imperial Capital, growing more distant by the moment, kept appearing before his eyes.

Damn it. Am I hearing things now, too?

Annoying as it was, Taishan was probably right that there hadn't been a sound. If a Peak master a step above him hadn't heard it, then there was nothing to hear.

Even if Mujin *had* heard something, it must have been the faint noise of an insect or an animal moving.

Then why do I feel like this?

Hyuk Mujin frowned harder and thumped his chest.

His heart kept pounding when it hadn't before, as though an invisible hand were squeezing it tight.

Something feels wrong.

Along with the inexplicable unease, the face of someone he'd parted with a few shichen[3386] ago suddenly flashed through his mind.

[3386] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese unit of time lasting about two hours.

Just one mission.

The last voice he'd heard before leaving still echoed in his ears.

Oh, one more thing.

Yes?

Be careful. You and everyone else.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

Hyuk Mujin had answered the warning with a grin. Then he and the rest of the Fire Dragon Pavilion had left the Imperial Capital, bound for the border between Jiangsu and Zhejiang Provinces.

For the very place written on the note Jin Taekyung had given him.

The mission's going fine… so what's wrong with me?

Everything was going smoothly, yet his chest felt unbearably tight.

The Captain—Jin Taekyung—had acted so strangely that the memory pricked at him like a fishbone caught in his throat.

Taekyung usually laughed with him over nothing, hit him for getting cheeky, and cursed him without holding back. Today, Mujin had seen none of that.

"Hyukmu!"

"…Ah."

Snapping out of his thoughts, Hyuk Mujin realized he'd stopped walking again.

Then he saw his companions waiting a short distance ahead, and his heart sank.

Grave eyes. Troubled faces.

Everyone except Taishan was looking at him the same way.

"Everyone…"

Hyuk Mujin barely swallowed a groan. At last, he thought he understood the unease that had been squeezing his chest.

"Did you all know?"

Namho answered his halting question in a heavy voice.

"Yes. More or less."

"The Captain told you?"

"No. Senior Jeok gave us a warning beforehand. He knew what choice his Disciple would make."

"Then why was I the only one—"

"If he'd told you to leave because you'd be a burden, would you have obeyed without a fuss?"

"…!"

"I don't like this situation either. No—none of us do."

For a moment, Hyuk Mujin had nothing to say.

He understood perfectly well how they felt about being burdens instead of help. He understood why Jin Taekyung had lied to send him away.

And it was the truth.

But… but…

Still, it shouldn't be like this.

Hyuk Mujin bit down on his lip until it bled and turned his head. Then, for an instant, he forgot the entire situation and muttered in a dazed voice.

"Huh…?"

Far away, countless figures moved through the darkness, shaking the forest as they passed.

Too many to count, yet he couldn't sense a single presence among them.

What are those?

The same question arose in everyone's mind. So did a fear none of them could explain.

This time, instinct rather than reason moved Hyuk Mujin.

No—it moved them all.

Whoosh!

Chapter 904

The situation in the Grand Banquet Hall had already spiraled beyond anyone's control.

The festive music had long since fallen silent. The threefold cheers of "A thousand years!" celebrating the birth of an heir had given way to screams and shouts.

At last, the fuse had been lit.

The banquet was over.

But another banquet had yet to end.

A Hongmen Banquet,[3387] where weapons would replace smiles, and blood would spill instead of wine.

A tremendous roar announced the start of that horrific feast, shaking the hall in every direction.

BOOOOM!

The ground shuddered, and a terrible wave of heat erupted. At that moment, a figure shot out from beyond the blazing flames and clouds of dust like a flash of light.

Whooosh!

Crunch!

The ground crumbled like tofu beneath the foot he barely managed to plant.

Jin Taekyung, the young man who'd just managed to steady himself after being hurled through the air with a sharp blast, spat the blood pooling in his mouth and muttered,

"So you're a cut above me…"

Speed, strength, a perfectly timed surprise attack—he'd made full use of them all, yet the gap between them was unmistakable.

His hand still tingled as he remembered thrusting out his palm.

Just as his full-power Flame Divine Palm was about to strike Cang Gong's chest, an icy energy had effortlessly suppressed his Scorching Yang Qi and shaken his entire body.

What the hell was that?

Despite all Jin Taekyung had seen—enough to rival many veterans of the martial world—he'd never felt energy like it.

Something more primal. Something he couldn't describe as merely Yin-Cold Qi.

But he had nowhere near enough to solve that mystery.

Not enough information or experience.

Not enough time, either.

[3387] A Hongmen Banquet is a treacherous feast, named for a historical banquet at which an assassination was attempted.

Step. Step.

Footsteps rang out clearly, even amid the chaos consuming the Grand Banquet Hall.

Cang Gong strolled across ground left horribly melted by the surge of Scorching Yang Qi. Then he stopped.

Right where he'd stood moments earlier.

"Five steps. Five whole steps."

There was admiration in his quiet voice.

At an absurdly young age, that martial artist had reached an astonishing level of skill.

To make this old man retreat five steps, in that battered condition.

Now that he'd experienced it firsthand, Cang Gong thought he understood why *that person* had taken such an interest in Jin Taekyung.

Why *that person* had ordered them to keep that young brat alive, even after losing two loyal servants—the Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—in the process.

As an enemy, he'd be the greatest obstacle. As an ally, he'd soon become a monster who could surpass even the Three Saints.

Cang Gong had no doubt they could win him over once they captured him.

If Jin Taekyung met the Lord of Heaven—if he felt that irresistible being's power even once—he would have no choice but to kneel before him.

Just as Cang Gong himself had.

"I must take him to the Lord of Heaven. No matter what."

The moment he said it, a dry voice cut in.

"Take who to whom?"

Fwoosh.

The air for hundreds of feet around them grew scorching hot.

Cang Gong saw a bald, middle-aged man approaching through the heat haze rising from the ground. His pale lips parted.

"Fire King Jeok Cheongang."

"How dare you toss this old man's name around, you ball-less bastard?"

"You two really are alike in speech and behavior. I can't tell whether the disciple learned from the master or the master from the disciple."

Jeok Cheongang answered flatly. "Usually, the disciple learns from the master. Though a rootless bastard like you wouldn't know that."

"Roots, huh? I had those once. A master and fellow disciples who were like family."

"I see. So did your master teach you to cut off your own balls, too?"

"No."

A murderous smile spread across Cang Gong's lips.

“He taught me never to forget my roots, no matter what happened. I haven’t forgotten his words for a single moment.”

“I don’t know what long-winded story you’ve got, but to hell with his teachings. You won’t need to remember them anymore.”

Jeok Cheongang raised his fist and grinned.

“Everyone who’s taken a hit from this old man ended up that way.”

He glanced around and added, “Though it looks like plenty of others would love to tear you apart, too.”

He wasn’t exaggerating.

Nearly two thousand members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard surrounded them in a circle. Every one of them was among the Great Nation’s finest troops, martial artists ranging from Supreme First Rate to Peak.

And that wasn’t all.

The Imperial Guards were considered a cut below the Embroidered Uniform Guard, who protected the Emperor and the imperial family, but they were elite troops in their own right. They’d arrived late, taken positions on the outer walls of the Grand Banquet Hall, and drawn their bows.

Five thousand men in all.

More than enough to call an army—and in quality, they could rival a force of a hundred thousand.

Yet Cang Gong merely looked at the countless spears, swords, and arrowheads surrounding him.

Or rather, he looked past them to the one man watching him from the high platform.

“The hunting dogs have slipped their leashes and are running wild without even knowing where they’ll die, while their cunning master sits back and watches.”

Just as he always had.

Cang Gong laughed aloud.

Then his laughter stopped dead, and a thunderous command burst from his pale lips.

“Attack!”

BOOOOM!

The immense internal energy carried in his voice shook the Grand Banquet Hall. At that instant—

Thrust! Slash!

A gleaming sword blade burst from an Embroidered Uniform Guard’s chest. Too stunned even to feel the pain, he stared at the steel piercing his golden armor.

“W-Why…?”

Shock and disbelief filled his wide eyes.

Even as death rushed toward him, he wanted to know.

Why was he dying like this? Why had a comrade he'd called hyung[3388] for more than ten years stabbed him in the back?

"Ghk. D-Dong hyung[3389]?"

Why?

They weren't related by blood, but they'd promised to treat each other as sworn brothers.

Dozens—hundreds—of times, they'd raised their cups together, encouraging each other, pledging their brotherhood and swearing loyalty to their country and His Majesty the Emperor.

But when he forced out that one call through the blood rising in his throat, the answer came in a flat voice he'd never heard in all their ten years together.

"Heaven above, earth below. All demons bow in reverence."

"…!"

Those were the last words he heard.

Crunch.

The sword twisted and pulled free. His lifeless body toppled to the ground.

Everywhere.

Thrust!

All around—

Slash!

Again and again—

Shhhk!

Severed heads rolled across the ground. Limbs and blood flew through the air.

In the blink of an eye, hundreds of the two thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards were dead.

Killed by their own comrades. By superiors, subordinates, and men they'd cherished like brothers.

"…!"

"…!"

Muffled shouts burst out from every direction. The traitors and the betrayed, those who fought to protect and those who fought to take, clashed with one another.

Clang-clang-clang!

Slash! Thrust!

"Aaagh!"

[3388] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[3389] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Screams echoed as swordlight flashed ceaselessly through the darkness.

Someone's hand, still clutching a torch, twitched in a pool of blood.

Then another darkness spread over the horrific melee that had erupted beneath the night sky.

Fwooooooosh.

Some who heard the sound thought it was rain. Another man, panting as he waited for death, remembered the broad plains of his hometown.

A strong wind sweeping in from far away had made just such a sound across those fields.

The ripe grain and grasses would bow, and the great tree where the village held its festivals would shake its abundant branches and leaves.

But the nameless man realized he'd never return to the hometown he missed.

Ah.

The darkness spreading across the sky was no darkness at all. Countless arrows were raining down.

They spread across the sky as they rushed toward the people below—or toward the Emperor they'd sworn their loyalty to.

Cough.

He spat blood mixed with fragments of his innards.

This wasn't how it was supposed to be.

He hadn't left his family and his hometown to die so pointlessly.

Damn it.

He stared at the darkness rushing toward him and waited for death to end his pain and despair.

Then he saw it.

Fwoosh—BOOOOM!

A great blaze swallowed the darkness.

Countless arrows burned away without a trace. Through that overwhelming heat, a young man plunged toward the ground like a hawk diving for prey.

BOOM!

Why did a roar that should have sounded like thunder reach him so faintly, as though it had come from hundreds of yards away?

As his vision dimmed, he tried to remember the young man's name.

Why couldn't he say it? Why couldn't he ask him to save him, to send him home?

With darkness closing over his eyes, all he could do was watch. Flames consumed the unending rain of arrows, and traitors fell like bundles of straw wherever the young man moved.

Two beings began a battle that shook heaven and earth. He could hardly believe they were made of flesh and blood like him.

Bang! Bang! BOOOOM!

Scorching heat. Shuddering cold.

Flames and white flashes swept the hall without pause, setting the night ablaze and freezing it over.

The countless bodies still piling up amid sprays of blood served as firewood.

And the life of one unfortunate man, made to suffer a little longer than the rest, as a sacrifice.

But at the end of that horrific wait, the nameless member of the Embroidered Uniform Guard managed to remember the young man's name—the one he'd almost forgotten.

Jin Taekyung. Right. It was Jin Taekyung.

Strange.

He lay dying in a pool of blood, in the middle of a sea of corpses and blood, yet he didn't feel cold at all.

It's warm.

He watched the flames surging between flashing spears and swords. Then, unable to fight the sleep overtaking him, he closed his eyes.

He thought of the hometown he would never return to.

People who love to talk say only two things can kill a Supreme Peak master: time and his own carelessness.

Right now, I wanted to tell those people one thing.

Then why don't you try fighting them?

A Supreme Peak master is still made of flesh and blood.

To someone who doesn't know any better, he might look like a superhuman who can take down hundreds or thousands of enemies. But he has limits.

Especially when at least half of those hundreds or thousands are Peak masters.

Swish! Slice!

The tip of a spear someone thrust out skimmed past my cheek by a hair. Getting my skin sliced open by the internal energy packed into its blade was just the standard package. My fist returning the favor was a bonus.

Wham!

My Flame Divine Palm struck the Embroidered Uniform Guard—no, the traitor planted by Dark Heaven—in the chest. He flew backward like a puppet with its strings cut.

Dead on the spot.

But someone else filled the gap. The others moved more cautiously now, and faster.

Damn it.

If they'd only been martial artists, they would've been much easier to deal with. But they were soldiers, too—a force with both powerful martial arts and an army's discipline.

Slash! Thrust!

I snatched a spear from someone's hands and swung it wildly, glaring past the shoulders of the enemies surrounding me.

Why the hell?!

I wanted to shout it.

Why weren't they helping? How could they stand there and watch, even now?

The Emperor stood where I was looking. Baek Yeon and So Gyo remained beside him, guarding him like stone statues.

And now there was someone else in my line of sight.

An unwelcome guest.

Whoosh!

A sharp sound cut through the air. A dozen or so Embroidered Uniform Guards who'd been fighting nearby stopped moving.

Their eyes widened in disbelief.

Then, as if to reveal the cold truth, faint lines of blood appeared on their necks, growing darker by the second.

Gurgle—SHHHK!

Blood beaded along the cuts, then sprayed like fountains. The man who'd swept past them watched their bodies fall like rotten trees. He looked at me and sighed.

"Why did you do it? If you'd simply trusted me and followed along, everything could have gone smoothly."

Instead of answering Ma Sanbao's bullshit—the kind even the mutt next door could understand—I brought my spearhead down.

Whoosh!

Chapter 905

The torches wavered. Blood dark enough to see even in the gloom burst out on every side.

Clang-clang-clang!

Thrust!

Well-honed blades met in flashes of swordlight. Cries of pain followed.

“Gyaaaagh!”

“Ghk, gah!”

With a dying cry that announced the end, someone nameless met their death, and someone else stepped into the empty space they left behind.

Again and again.

A cycle of death that would not end until one side was wiped out.

The Emperor sat on his throne without so much as a tremor, as though to prove the weight of those two words—Son of Heaven. He watched the Grand Banquet Hall turn into a battlefield.

It’s been a long time since I’ve seen a sight like this.

He wore a brilliantly embroidered dragon robe now, but little more than a decade ago, he had been a general who crossed battlefields in armor.

The fourth prince of the Great Nation, with neither the prospect nor the desire to inherit the throne.

No one had expected the man who led an army against border warlords and nomads to ascend the throne.

Not even the man himself.

“Strange how things turn out. Truly strange. Wouldn’t you agree?”

At the Emperor’s sudden murmur, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, replied in a heavy voice. He stood beside the throne like an iron tower.

“This subordinate failed in his duty.”

A full third of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, whose duty was to protect the imperial family, had turned their blades against it. The Imperial Guards responsible for the Outer Palace were raining arrows down without pause.

The Emperor had not been entirely unprepared for the existence of traitors, but Cang Gong’s shadow had fallen far darker than he’d expected.

Across the imperial family. No—across the entire Great Nation.

Shhh-shhh-shh—clang!

Hundreds of arrows fired straight at the Emperor bounced off harmlessly.

The Emperor moved his lips toward the Embroidered Uniform Guard who had blocked the attack by forming a wall with their massive iron shields.

“Advance.”

One short command was enough.

A hundred martial artists, handpicked from among the finest of the Great Nation’s greatest force, launched themselves forward without hesitation.

Away from the Emperor’s side and into the battlefield stained with death and screams.

Whoooosh!

Dozens of yards vanished in an instant.

A hundred spears and swords swung together, flashing as they bore down on the traitors.

Whiiing!

Slice! Thrust!

“Gyaaaagh!”

Screams and blood erupted without pause.

The martial prowess of warriors at the very brink of the Peak realm—overwhelming, and horribly powerful.

But even that could not turn the tide of battle. At its center, true monsters beyond human limits were running wild.

BOOOOM!

Rrrumble!

A tremendous roar and tremor shook the area. Beyond a pillar of fire that surged high into the air, piercing the darkness, a painfully white light blazed.

Shhk!

Space split open.

Everyone who felt that chill, like frost in the depths of winter, shuddered as if on cue. Then, as their vision slowly tilted, they understood.

Ah.

The cold they had just felt was death.

Rrrumble!

Dozens of bodies toppled like rotten old trees. Their blood-soaked armor no longer shone gold, and the gray eyes looking down at them were cold.

“Is that all you have?”

Whump!

A casual palm strike crushed a man’s whole body.

“The Emperor’s hunting dogs. The might of the imperial family.”

Craack!

A light stomp sent the ground rippling for dozens of yards around him.

“I asked if that’s all you have!”

BWOOOM!

The shout, charged with immense internal energy, burst through the compressed air. It shook bodies and minds hardened by grueling training and tore at eardrums.

“Ghk.”

Groans rose all around. The Embroidered Uniform Guards staggered, clutching their bleeding ears, as another white flash hurtled toward them.

No—it was just about to.

Fwoosh.

Somewhere, flames flickered.

In an instant, the air, cold as ice a moment ago, boiled like lava. Fire swallowed even the darkness.

BOOM!

Would a volcano sound like that if it erupted?

The thought flashed through everyone’s mind as the flames poured toward one man alone.

An old man with pale skin.

Cang Gong’s gray eyes filled with terrible heat.

BOOOOM!

Impact. An explosion.

The dreadful shock wave that followed hurled friend and foe alike through the air. Cang Gong was no exception.

Shhhhh. Thud.

Driven back by the immense force, he barely managed to stop himself. He straightened his bent back and fixed his gaze on one man.

“When the situation demands you fight with everything you have, you waste your strength showing off against children. You must’ve eaten your age through your ass.”

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

As Jeok approached through the heat haze rising around him, Cang Gong’s lips twisted.

“And you’re no different. In the end, didn’t you earn the title of Fire King by killing countless weaklings?”

“Even without balls, you should get your facts straight. The Demonic Cultists I killed weren’t mere weaklings. They were arsonists. Burning them alive wouldn’t have been punishment enough.”

“Then why did you kill the other Demonic Cultists? They had done nothing to you.”

“One day, I woke up to find my ancestral home in flames. How do you think that felt?”

Jeok Cheongang did not wait for an answer.

“Awful. Fucking awful. So I kicked every last one of them in the ass and sent them to the afterlife. That way, even if they were reborn, they’d never set fire to someone else’s home again.”

“In other words, it was personal revenge.”

“That’s right. I didn’t much like what those bastards were doing anyway.”

Jeok Cheongang raised a fist wreathed in rolling flames and added,

“Just like you.”

Swish—BOOM!

Thousands of soldiers filled the Grand Banquet Hall, but not one of them saw how Jeok Cheongang moved—or how Cang Gong evaded that terrifying attack.

A tiny handful of people were the exception. They were more than worthy of being called superhuman.

“If I were in his place, how long could I last?”

The Emperor had watched it all. Baek Yeon answered his question.

“A hundred moves.”

“You don’t hesitate to be cruel. I put no small effort into reaching this realm.”

The Emperor gave a bitter smile. Baek Yeon replied evenly.

“It would be the same for anyone. The only question is how long they could last. The outcome would not change.”

“Even if you went out there, Baek Yeon?”

“As Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, I would certainly win. As a lone martial artist, I would lose by a hair.”

“Then which are you now—a martial artist, or the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard?”

“This subordinate has always been the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard. I obey only Your Majesty’s commands. And…”

Baek Yeon’s voice fell to a murmur.

“The late Emperor’s final order was for me to plan for the future alongside the fourth prince.”

“…!”

The Emperor’s eyes trembled.

How could he forget that day? The voice he had heard for the last time?

More than ten years had passed since then.

Frost had settled early on the head of the young man burdened with more than he could bear. The infant who had once been swaddled in blankets had grown into a boy, now sharing this very moment with him.

“What on earth—”

The boy struggled as though he might shake off the palace attendants holding him and rush onto the battlefield.

“What on earth are you thinking?”

His eyes blazed with confusion and anger as he glared at the Emperor.

“Why? Why won’t you help them? They’re risking their lives for Your Majesty…!”

BOOOOM!

The rest of his words were swallowed by the roar that burst out with the flames.

The next moment, Prince Shangshan saw a familiar face amid another fierce battle across the hall. The man was rising to his feet, using a spear shaft broken in half as a cane.

Shangshan let out a quiet groan.

“Jin Taekyung.”

He could recognize him at a glance, even from far away.

No. How could he fail to recognize him?

It was Jin Taekyung.

The first person to bring life to the young prince’s dull, unchanging days. The only one who had treated him as someone other than a prince.

Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao clearly remembered the day they had first met.

“Could I become like you?”

After much thought, he had asked Jin Taekyung that question. Jin had answered without hesitation.

“Of course. You can.”

Shangshan had meant it. He wanted to be like Jin Taekyung.

Not simply because Jin was a formidable martial artist. A man once dismissed as his family’s unwanted child had defeated powerful enemies and won everyone’s affection. Shangshan found it astonishing—and enviable.

Though he was a royal more honored than anyone in the world, the young prince had always been lonely. In that young martial artist, he had seen something of himself.

A few days ago, Jin had dared to stroke his hair. Shangshan could still feel the warmth of his hand.

“I hope we meet again. Then I can repay the debt I owe you.”

“Your Highness.”

“Yes?”

“Don’t you know? Friends don’t owe each other anything.”

It had been the first time anyone had called him a friend. The first time anyone had stroked his hair as though he were an ordinary child.

That made him want all the more to keep his promise—to repay what he owed Jin Taekyung and return his kindness.

Jin was his one and only friend.

“Please, please save him.”

Shangshan did not know what was happening or what lay behind it. Still, he bowed his head and fell to his knees without hesitation.

Before his only blood relative.

He pleaded with the ruler of the continent, who could move several Supreme Peak masters with a single word.

“I will do anything you ask of me. If you order your younger brother to leave the Great Nation, I will obey. But please, do not refuse the first and last request this brother of yours will ever make.”

“…!”

“Save him. Save Jin Taekyung, Your Majesty!”

As the Emperor watched Shangshan prostrate himself and cry out, an indescribable emotion crossed his face.

Relief. Pride. Perhaps even sorrow. Amid that swirl of feelings was something he could not bring himself to say.

Not ‘Your Majesty’… Wouldn’t you call me ‘older brother’?

His lips parted, but no words came out. Nor did he nod at Shangshan’s plea.

No—he could not.

Everything that happened on this battlefield today had been entrusted to one person more than a decade ago.

No matter how I think about it, I can’t understand why you’re doing nothing, even in a situation like this.

So Gyo answered the Emperor’s quiet Sound Transmission in her ear.

I’m not standing by. I’m watching.

Her gaze remained fixed on Jin Taekyung, unwavering as it had been from the start.

Until he shows his true self.

Chapter 906

I didn’t know what to call this.

A melee?

A bloodbath?

Maybe both. Everywhere I stepped, I was trampling the corpse of someone I didn’t know, while enemy spears, swords, and arrowheads came hurtling in without pause, from the ground and the sky alike.

Even now.

“Look out!”

One of the Embroidered Uniform Guards heard my shout and jolted, twisting at the waist.

Fffft!

His armor split with a sharp whistle.

The traitor who’d tried to ambush him amid the chaos missed by a hair. Without hesitation, I kicked a crescent blade lying on the ground.

Whoooosh! Thud!

There wasn’t even the usual dying cry.

The blade shot out like a flash of light, piercing its target and then skewering a couple of nearby enemies like meat on a spit. The Embroidered Uniform Guard, who’d barely escaped with his life, gave me a slight nod.

“Thank y—”

He never raised his head again.

Thwack!

An arrow pierced his throat, straight through his Adam’s apple.

He collapsed with blood gurgling in his throat. Enemies trampled his body as they rushed in, swinging their weapons at anyone in reach.

All accompanied by a calm voice that had no place in a situation like this—which made it all the more chilling.

“Heaven above, earth below.”

“All demons bow in reverence.”

Why did they remind me of the deranged fanatics I’d fought right before coming to Murim?

“Fucking lunatics…”

Short cries of dismay rang out here and there. The Embroidered Uniform Guards had continued fighting calmly despite the sudden betrayal of their allies, as if to prove the weight of the golden armor they wore. But even they looked afraid as they watched the traitors, who had become entirely different people.

Or maybe they feared the martial prowess of someone they couldn't hope to face.

Splash.

A leather shoe sank into a pool of blood as its owner stepped forward.

One of the Embroidered Uniform Guards had backed away without realizing it. A groan slipped through his lips.

"Ma Sanbao…"

That's right. It was him.

Ma Sanbao, the East Depot's Brush-Holding Eunuch.

Its second-in-command and de facto leader.

Or rather, that was the identity he'd used to deceive the world. Now he moved toward me.

So fast that "approaching" hardly did it justice—he moved like a flash of light.

Whoosh! BOOM!

His blows rained down like lightning from above. Every time I blocked one, my hands went numb.

My breathing had grown rougher than before, throwing off movements that should have flowed like water.

Huff. Huff.

As I panted, I wondered whether I was struggling this badly because of my condition—or because my opponent was simply that formidable.

I didn't have long to wonder.

Shhk!

The flexible sword curved like a living snake and grazed the bridge of my nose.

Hot blood ran from the cut. I retreated through the burning pain, and a low laugh reached my ear.

"What happened to all that momentum you had at the start, hmm?"

Instead of answering, I turned my head. A dagger sprang from Ma Sanbao's voluminous sleeve and pierced the empty space beside me like a streak of light.

Thwack!

Another life ended with a sickening sound.

Ma Sanbao went on as if nothing had happened.

"That's a shame. If you hadn't dodged, that young Embroidered Uniform Guard would still be breathing."

I looked at Ma Sanbao, who was taunting me, and wondered:

If I hadn't dodged, would the guard have survived?

Could he have made it through this battle and returned to his family someday?

I didn't know. I didn't know anything.

The pointless guilt made me feel like shit, even though someone else was the one who owed the dead guard an apology.

Why…?

I wanted to turn around. I wanted to look the Emperor and So Gyo in the eye—the two who had thrown me, Jeok Cheongang, and even their own subordinates into this battlefield, only to stand by and watch. I wanted to ask them why they'd held this damn banquet. Why they weren't stepping in when they had the power to turn the tide.

"Why the hell?!"

I couldn't hold back the shout any longer. But it wasn't the Emperor or So Gyo who answered.

It was Ma Sanbao.

"Do you still not understand why they're standing by and doing nothing?"

He let out a derisive laugh and continued.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. The Emperor used you too, in the end. Just as we tried to use you and the Fire King to get rid of So Gyo."

"…!"

"Borrow another's blade to kill. There's no better way to keep blood off your hands. Especially when the blades are as fine as the Fire King and the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon."

I wanted to tell him to shut his damn mouth.

But no matter how badly I wanted to deny it, I couldn't speak.

It was all too plausible.

If the Emperor was anything like the man I'd experienced firsthand…

And with that woman, So Gyo, still a complete mystery…

"You and your master have only one role left. Fight for your lives until, in the end, you die."

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

The flexible sword became dozens of blades, whistling toward me from every direction.

A sword technique of extreme speed, pushed to its very limit.

But however densely the afterimages surrounded me, only one blade was real.

Clang!

A clash far too loud to have come from two weapons meeting sent me sliding back.

Ma Sanbao kept swinging the flexible sword, giving me no pause. His voice came from beyond it.

"The Great Nation, the Emperor—it's always been like this. To the rulers who hold this vast land, people like you and me, people of Murim, aren't subjects to govern."

Whoosh-whoosh! Slice!

The pressure behind his sword cut through my skin. Thin sprays of blood scattered into the air.

"That's why I followed my master and pledged my loyalty to that person. It's why you'll die here today. The Emperor only wants to protect Prince Shangshan. He won't play the cards he's kept hidden just to save a pack of martial-world ruffians."

"What?"

A realization flashed through my mind, and my eyes widened.

Even though there was considerable distance between us, I suddenly thought of someone fighting a thunderous battle alongside Jeok Cheongang far away.

Could it be?

No. There was no *could* about it.

Ma Sanbao had said it himself. This wasn't a guess. It was a certainty.

Krrrrang!

Their different Forces collided, spitting sparks.

My spear had once been a single weapon. Ma Sanbao's fierce assault had broken it into two short spears. I crossed them to block his flexible sword and felt a chill coming off the blade, stopped inches from my face.

"Cang Gong. Were you his disciple?"

"Cang Gong? How dare you call him a servant of that sinister, weak Emperor?"

Ma Sanbao's lips twisted.

"Eastern Heaven Demon Lord. That is the new name the great and all-powerful Lord of Heaven bestowed on his loyal servant."

"…!"

"And that Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's disciple will bring you to your knees."

At that moment—

Whirr.

The springy blade of the flexible sword bent.

It slipped over the spear shaft blocking its way like a living snake and flashed toward me. I swung my crossed short spears upward with all my strength.

Clang!

The flexible sword veered away from my chest.

But I'd only survived a dangerous moment. The attack wasn't over.

Wham!

Hk!

My breath caught, and my vision flashed.

A fist struck my exposed chest. I staggered back more than ten steps, giving Ma Sanbao an opening he couldn't afford to miss.

Tap.

One step.

At the same time, Ma Sanbao's figure vanished like an illusion.

But even with my battered body and dulled senses, I reacted in time.

Left!

The instant I was sure, I flung out one hand.

Broken in two, the spear had lost the advantage of its long reach. But the shortened shaft was the perfect length and speed for a throw. I sent it flying with all my strength.

Whoooosh!

A single fierce whistle ripped through the air.

Then came a tremendous impact.

BOOM!

Dust billowed from the ground.

And then—

Shhhhk!

Space split open.

The flexible sword had knocked my short spear aside. Now it came through the dust, blazing with Force and cutting the cloud apart.

Ma Sanbao's taunting Sound Transmission reached me with it.

—Don't worry. I'll only cut you enough to leave you barely alive.

That was his mistake.

The world slowed. I could see every one of the dozens of sword-images raining down through the air.

Cut me? And only enough to leave me alive?

What a joke.

He was talking like that while his opponent was still standing on two perfectly good legs.

Win a life-and-death duel, and you could spit on your opponent. Boast about your strength. Laugh in his face.

But…

You do that after it's over.

My body was heavy as waterlogged cotton, and the internal energy that usually surged through me like a wave was coming in broken strands.

It didn't matter.

My eyes hadn't wavered. Neither had the hand gripping my one remaining short spear.

I see it.

Shwoosh!

The spear tip pierced a single precise point. Dozens of sword-images vanished as it struck the real blade.

BOOM!

The impact sent the figure flying, unable to withstand the force of the collision.

Not me.

Ma Sanbao.

Crunch.

He planted a foot hard enough to tear up the ground and barely managed to steady himself. His eyes widened as he stared at me.

Tap.

I was already right in front of him.

“You bastard!”

Ma Sanbao cried out, his flexible sword cutting through the air at a speed worthy of being called extreme. It scattered Force like a glacier—colder and more merciless still.

Shwoooosh!

Facing that force, which seemed capable of freezing everything it touched, I drew up every last bit of internal energy in my body.

Fwoosh.

Wet firewood caught flame.

I poured the Scorching Yang Qi that surged like fire through my acupoints, as unstable as twisted railway tracks, into my hand and grabbed the blade just as it began to pierce my side.

Krrk, KRAAAASH!

Power collided with power.

Agony shot through both hands.

This wasn’t Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade, catching a weapon between bare fingers with precise timing and speed.

This was just a brute-force grab.

“You crazy—!”

No martial artist could blame Ma Sanbao for saying that.

This really was insane.

You might get away with it against someone at least a level below you. Against a master of similar skill—especially one with greater internal energy—you’d lose both arms in an instant.

But…

It’s different when the lunatic grabbing the blade has been busting his ass to raise his Muscles and Bones through the System.

If my other stats were blue-chip stocks, Muscles and Bones were a savings account I'd kept adding to with every level and every training session.

So what about now, more than a year after I'd gotten the System?

What level am I again?

I smiled.

I endured the horrible pain as my palm turned into a shredded mess, and looked into Ma Sanbao's eyes, bulging as if they were about to burst.

Then I gave his words back to him, changing just a few.

"Don't worry. I'll stab you just enough to kill you."

"…!"

Ma Sanbao tried to shout, but no sound came out.

Krrk!

The short spear in my hand pierced his throat just as his lips began to part.

"Ghk. Kgh."

Blood gurgled in his throat. The light faded from his eyes as he stared at me.

Chapter 907

I won’t say the fight with Ma Sanbao was fiercer or harder than any I’d ever fought.

There had been plenty of stronger opponents in the hellish battlefields I’d fought my way through. Even now, I could name several who’d been far worse than him.

But one thing was certain: today, Ma Sanbao had been stronger than me.

No. More precisely, I was weaker than usual.

The System was practically sealed, and my body, wrecked by the aftereffects of One Annihilation, wouldn’t move the way I wanted it to.

Even so, I was the one still standing.

In this merciless world ruled by the law of the jungle, Ma Sanbao had made a small but fatal mistake.

He’d mistaken himself for someone a step above me.

“If you wanted to take me alive… you should’ve come at me ready to kill me from the start.”

I looked into Ma Sanbao’s empty eyes as I whispered, then drove the short spear deeper through his throat.

Crunch. Crack.

Bone fragments burst through his skin with a sickening sound.

I didn’t let go until the spear had severed his carotid artery and followed his collarbone down toward his heart. Freed from my grip at last, Ma Sanbao’s body slowly toppled.

The spear remained buried deep inside him like a tree root.

Thud. Splash.

There was no System message telling me I’d defeated an enemy. No clear, familiar chime.

But this was enough.

Finally. One down.

Panting, I stared at the corpse lying motionless in a pool of blood, then let out a shout charged with internal energy.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan has killed Ma Sanbao, Brush-Holding Eunuch of the East Depot!”

Before anyone could grasp what that meant, I plunged back into the battlefield, where swords and spears were flying.

Whoosh! Crunch!

Short, simple movements. The bare minimum of internal energy.

I dodged, struck, and smashed.

Crack!

I crushed the face of a man muttering those eight words like a mantra—“Heaven above, earth below. All demons bow in reverence.” I was sick of hearing them.

Whsssh!

As his body crumpled, its features mangled beyond recognition, blades flew at me from either side. I jerked my head out of their path.

Clang!

The two blades missed me by a hand’s breadth and struck each other. Ignoring the vibration ringing in my ears, I thrust out my torn hand.

Boom!

Hot, compressed air burst outward.

I’d put only three-tenths of my internal energy into the Flame Divine Palm. Even so, the force and heat of that strike were enough to kill most Peak masters on the spot.

“Gah…!”

The man flew backward, spraying dark red blood.

Whether that nameless enemy lived or died was no longer my concern. What he’d left behind was another matter.

Tap.

His sword had already slipped from his hand. I caught the hilt and swung it in one smooth motion.

Shhhh!

Space split open. Flames wrapped around the blade, heating the air and burning flesh and bone.

Simple and swift. Too powerful to stop.

And at the end of it came my enemies’ blood and screams.

Fwoosh!

“Gaaah!”

I pushed forward, drenched in blood spraying like a fountain. I dodged the countless blades crashing in from every direction, knocked them aside, then sent them flying right back where they came from.

When the sword broke, I used a spear. When the spear snapped, an ax or a dagger.

And if I had none of those, I used arms and legs harder than steel.

Crunch!

Boom!

I broke the bones and crushed the flesh of every enemy in my way.

There was no need to invoke some grand concept like all streams returning to the sea.

Every weapon in the world had been made to fight more efficiently. Martial arts existed for the same reason.

Stab. Slash. Strike.

To me, martial arts were connections between countless points and lines.

When your life was on the line, you couldn't afford to rule out any means.

If a weapon could kill an enemy as quickly and surely as possible, its shape didn't matter.

Just like now.

Cr-rack!

A corpse collapsed, its neck bent at an unnatural angle.

The enemies kept blocking my way, no matter how many I killed. Their lips never stopped murmuring those mantra-like words, but I could see the emotion in their eyes.

Fear.

Huff. Huff.

I fought to keep my ragged breathing quiet. Every muscle in my body throbbed as if I'd been electrocuted, and the hand that had grabbed Ma Sanbao's sword could barely feel pain anymore.

After pulling something that crazy, I was probably in terrible shape.

But I couldn't show even the slightest weakness.

Wolves hunted in packs, but no matter how hungry they were, they couldn't bare their teeth at a lion that roared and charged them.

They only tried to sink their teeth into a lion's nape when it started backing away.

Splash.

My heavy step sent the blood pooled around my ankles rippling.

Like the blood still seeping from the countless wounds carved into my body, the blood reflecting the night sky was dark red.

Can I do this?

A wave of exhaustion hit me.

I'd killed over a hundred of them by my rough count, yet enemies still filled my view.

The Great Nation's—no, Dark Heaven's—elite. They ranged from Supreme First Rate to the upper reaches of Peak.

Their individual prowess aside, I had to defeat every last one of those fanatics who worshiped the Lord of Heaven before I could reach Jeok Cheongang, who was still fighting a thunderous battle that seemed like it would never end.

Goddammit.

I didn't know.

We were gaining the upper hand without the Emperor's help, so why did unease still gnaw at me?

Why did that cloud-choked night sky look so ominous?

No. I knew.

This isn't all of it.

I couldn't see them anywhere, no matter how I looked: the assassins who were supposed to protect the Emperor, or the twin Supreme Peak masters who had guarded Qianqing Palace.

Even the number of Embroidered Uniform Guards in the Grand Banquet Hall was only half what I knew it should be.

And the same goes for Cang Gong.

The Emperor and Cang Gong.

The two men had crossed a point of no return, yet neither had revealed all his forces. They had to be concealing their moves, waiting for the other to show his hand first.

I wouldn't have been surprised if the entire Imperial Capital had split in two by now and was fighting a bloody battle.

Fuck.

What a shitty mess.

Even so, I had to fight.

I had to survive.

The Dark Heaven dogs charging beneath that rain of arrows weren't the only ones I had to survive. There were also the Emperor and So Gyo, and I didn't even know whether they were enemies or allies.

What the hell are you planning?

I turned toward the high platform in the distance.

Baek Yeon and So Gyo stood on either side of the Emperor. With those two Supreme Peak masters, either of whom could turn the battle around in an instant, he watched the fighting.

I could also see Aehyang surrounded by a handful of palace attendants, and the young king kneeling for some reason.

My gaze lingered on them for a moment. Only then did the countless whistles crossing the sky reach my ears.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

A deep shadow fell over my head.

Hundreds of arrowheads flashed as they fell, all aimed at me alone. At the same moment, a red alarm bell rang violently inside my head.

Shit.

I knew before I moved.

Dodging them all would be next to impossible.

I was exhausted. My body and senses had grown sluggish, and I stood isolated in an open space with nowhere to evade the countless arrows fired by First Rate masters using internal energy.

Use as little strength as I can. Avoid anything fatal.

I gritted my teeth and pulled an abandoned spear from the ground. With my other hand, I reached toward the sky.

Whummm.

The air around me trembled.

I'd avoided using my Middle Dantian during the fight unless the danger was extreme, conserving my stamina. Now wasn't the time to weigh whether it would be bitter or sweet.

Bitter or not, I had to swallow it.

I had to bear it myself.

There was no way in hell I was going to fall here, of all places.

Just as I clenched my fist, ready to meet the arrows hurtling toward me with a ferocious whistle that seemed to tear through my ears—

"Turtle Shell! Defend!"

At a shout from someone whose voice sounded familiar, a group swept in with blinding speed and surrounded me.

They held up massive shields.

Bam-bam-bam!

Sparks lit up the darkness. Broken arrow fragments scattered in every direction. Moments later, a second rain of arrows came, and dozens of crescent-bladed polearms flashed toward it.

"Slash!"

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! Slice!

Blade Force swept across the sky in brilliant half-moons.

The powerful energy formed a kind of barrier, slicing apart every arrow that flew toward them. The scattered fragments couldn't pierce the gaps in their golden armor.

Clatter. Thud-thud-thud!

Countless fragments fell, their force spent.

I watched in silence, then spoke to the familiar face beneath a helmet pulled low.

"Should I thank you for that?"

Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, answered evenly.

"I didn't know you knew how to say thank you."

"I don't say it very often."

"I thought not. I wasn't expecting it."

"What about you?"

"When I owe someone, I thank them. Like now."

Clank.

Jeong Hogun struck his golden armor in a military salute. When he spoke again, his tone had changed.

"Thank you for helping His Majesty. And us."

"…Huh."

"I'm sure you have plenty to ask me, and plenty you want to say. But I'd like you to save it until after this is over."

Goddammit.

If he came out with something like that before I could even open my mouth, there was nothing left to say.

I clicked my tongue and watched the enemies pressing in from all sides.

"Hey. One question."

"Anything."

"That guy over there playing peeping Tom—is he on our side?"

Jeong Hogun flinched at "peeping Tom," then nodded.

"At least His Majesty is. We're on your side."

At least?

I understood immediately why he'd added those words.

So not So Gyo. No—more precisely, he doesn't know, either.

It had to be that. Ma Sanbao hadn't seemed to know, and neither had Cang Gong.

Who that mysterious woman was, or what she had in mind.

An unknown like that meant danger.

…Shit. Good thing I left the kids behind.

I muttered to myself and raised the ownerless spear I'd picked up moments ago, aiming it at the enemies surging toward us.

I thought of the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, who should be somewhere safe, waiting for Murim Alliance reinforcements that weren't coming.

They'd probably kick up a fuss later, repeating "Captain" like parrots. But if they'd stayed here, it wouldn't have been surprising if they were already dead—

"Captaiiin!"

"…?"

"Captaaaain!"

What the fuck?

I turned around, feeling as though I'd been possessed by a ghost, and spotted familiar faces appearing in the distance.

“Captaaaaaain!”

More precisely, I saw Hyuk Mujin at the head of the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, hollering at the top of his lungs.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

And countless black figures trailing behind him like a tail.

Chapter 908

For a moment, every thought in my head stopped.

What the hell is this?

I stared, mouth open, at the scene in the distance.

The Fire Dragon Pavilion members were running toward me, panic written all over their faces. A group of black-clad figures was racing after them.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The ground shook. Even the figures I could see numbered well over a thousand, all dressed in black from head to toe. As they drew closer, their chilling aura grew clearer. It could mean only one thing.

Enemies!

The instant I reached that conclusion, a red warning light flashed in my mind.

Shit.

I had no idea what had happened, but what I needed to do was clear.

The unknown figures had brought the battlefield to a momentary lull. I shouted at the Embroidered Uniform Guards.

“Quit standing there and pick up your weapons!”

I didn’t expect them to obey me just because I’d given an order. But beside me stood a man of considerable rank—a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

“Rally! Rally immediately!”

As Jeong Hogun’s shout roused the battlefield, I channeled my internal energy and kicked off the ground.

Boom!

Flamefire Path.

Flames burst from my toes, scorching the air. Riding the shock wave, I took one step, then another. The twenty-odd *jang*[3390] between me and the stone wall vanished, and the figures atop it came into view.

The Imperial Guards.

Along with the Embroidered Uniform Guard, they were one of the Great Nation’s elite forces, charged with protecting the Imperial Capital. They were also traitors who’d betrayed the Emperor and taken refuge in the shadow of the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who had lived behind the guise of Cang Gong.

From behind the high stone wall, they had been firing arrows without pause. Their bows were now aimed at the Fire Dragon Pavilion members who had appeared behind them alongside the black-clad figures.

[3390] A *jang* is a traditional length unit equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

At least, they were until I arrived.

“General, your orders!”

At the urgent call of someone who looked like a junior officer, a middle-aged man in ornate armor swung the baton in his hand without hesitation.

He swung it at me as I closed the dozens of *jang*[3391] between us in an instant.

“Loose!”

Thwang-thwang-thwang! Fwoooosh!

Nearly a thousand archers turned and released their taut bowstrings. Countless silver arrowheads, imbued with internal energy, blanketed the sky as they rained down on me.

It was a near-perfect volley, powerful enough that even a Supreme Peak master couldn’t ignore it.

But…

Not if they can’t hit me.

Boom!

Another burst of Flamefire Path exploded from my toes, and I shot forward like a cannonball.

A sudden burst of speed. A swerve.

Thup-thup-thup-thup!

Arrows whistled past behind me with a sound that made my skin crawl. I didn’t need to look back to know that the spot where I’d stood a moment ago was bristling with them.

Nor did I think the Imperial Guards, one of the Great Nation’s elite forces, would stop there.

“What the—!”

“Don’t lose your nerve! Loose!”

Their surprise at my speed lasted only a moment. Thoroughly trained, the Imperial Guards nocked new arrows and fired in one swift, fluid motion.

Fwoooosh!

Once.

Thup-thup-thup!

Then again.

“Fire! I said fire!”

“Begin staggered fire!”

Thwang-thwang!

I narrowly evaded the fourth rain of arrows, loosed in two successive waves.

Bang!

[3391] A *jang* is a traditional length unit equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Then I kicked off the ground and shot into the air. The Imperial Guards were nocking their fifth volley—the last they would get to fire—when they cried out.

“H-He’s coming!”

“Loose! Loose!”

It all happened in an instant: four volleys, and my passage through that dense storm of arrows to the top of the stone wall.

In the world that had slowed around me, a few of the quickest Imperial Guards obeyed the order. Their arrows cut through the air toward me.

Slowly. So slowly that I could hear the wind flowing along each advancing arrowhead.

Whoosh.

I reached toward the dozens of arrows flashing in the darkness, each imbued with internal energy. At the same time, I awakened the pulse I alone could feel at the center of my chest, at the point called the Jade Hall.

Stop.

At that instant—

Whoooosh!

An invisible power, utterly unlike internal energy, spread in every direction at my will. It erased the wind, stilled the air, and caught the dozens of arrows moving through it.

Rrrrrumble.

The air trembled. Time returned to its normal pace.

But the Imperial Guards looking up at me, standing in midair, remained frozen in shock.

“Th-This is insane…”

Someone’s groan broke the heavy silence. Reflected in their wide, staring eyes were dozens of arrows suspended as though caught by an invisible hand, with me at their center.

“A m-monster.”

“How… How is this possible?”

Shock. Fear. The questions of men who had seen something they couldn’t comprehend.

And then came the desperate resistance of the few who hadn’t given up.

“What are you waiting for? Shoot him!”

“B-But…”

“All Imperial Guards! Follow the General’s orders and take down that heinous—!”

I shot my hand out like a bolt of lightning toward the few officers screaming at their men.

Or, to be exact, I scattered the arrows I'd been holding with the power of my Middle Dantian.

Whoosh! Thup-thup-thup!

"G-Gah!"

"Gaaah!"

Screams followed the arrows' fierce whistle.

True to their reputation as Imperial Guards, each of them was a master of no small skill. But they couldn't dodge the arrows I sent flying as if I were controlling them.

Except one.

Clang-clang!

Arrows flew aside in a flash of swordlight.

The middle-aged man cut down the attacks converging on him from every direction in a single sweep. His Force shone as brilliantly as the armor that set him apart from the other Imperial Guards. A thought crossed my mind, and I said it aloud.

"One of the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac?"

The Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac: the collective title for the twelve Supreme Peak masters who represented the imperial court.

"Have you ever heard of the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac?"

"Sure. Aren't they the names of constellations?"

"It's also what they call the twelve Supreme Peak masters who represent the Imperial Capital. And half of them are on our side."

Ma Sanbao had told me that himself.

The middle-aged man fixed me with a grave look and tightened his grip on his great saber.

"Do you know me?"

"I know you well."

I nodded and went on.

"You're the treacherous piece of shit who betrayed the Emperor and sided with Dark Heaven. The asshole who wanted to turn me and my people into pincushions. And the asshole who's about to die."

"…!"

"That about covers it. If you need to add anything, spit it out yourself."

"…No. That's enough. Except for one thing."

His eyes gleamed as he added quietly, "I'm not the one who's going to die."

At that moment—

Whoosh!

His figure blurred.

Shifting Form and Position: a supreme movement technique available only to those who had reached the highest realms.

He kicked off the stone wall and sprang into the air. His great saber, longer and larger than most grown men, flashed across the space between us.

Its speed and power were worthy of a superhuman. Terrifying energy poured from the Force wrapped around the blade.

Strong.

I could tell at a glance how powerful this nameless man was. I could imagine the grueling training it had taken to reach his realm and become commander of the Imperial Guards.

But that was precisely why his saber would never touch me.

If you could take in an entire mountain range at a glance, you had to be looking down from higher up.

Whoooosh!

One step was enough.

The great saber tore through distorted space, but it couldn't match my speed as I moved through the air as if it were solid ground. Only the strands of Force it sent flying barely grazed me.

Sizzle.

Pain like a burn.

The pressure split the skin exposed beneath my tattered clothes. Drops of my blood scattered through the air and mingled with someone else's.

Grrk. Cough.

The middle-aged man's body shuddered with a wet, rattling sound. Something that hadn't been there a moment ago protruded from his thick, bull-like neck.

Something that glinted coldly in the dark.

"Grrk. Wh-What is this?"

He could barely maintain Stepping on Empty Air. Still, he felt for the arrowhead, as though he couldn't believe it was there. I watched him calmly.

"I've received so many unexpected gifts that I was starting to feel bad. Here, you can have one back."

"Seizing an Object Through Empty Space?"

"Similar, but different."

Tap.

I touched the center of his swaying chest with a finger.

"Much harder, though. And more certain."

"…The Middle Dantian. It's the Middle Dantian."

Cough.

He spat out a mouthful of blood and looked at me, his eyes trembling. Then, with his last strength, he struggled to raise the great saber he still held.

His voice faded as he spoke.

“I… I am the Golden Ox Palace of the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac, the Chief Commander of the Imperial Guards, and one who devotes his life to the great and almighty Lord of Heaven…”

He never finished.

Slip.

Did the saber slide from his hand first? Or did his body tip as death closed in?

I didn’t know which struck the ground first. I didn’t care.

Man and weapon fell together. As a dull thud rose from below, I stepped onto the stone wall.

Right into the middle of the Imperial Guards, who stood frozen like statues.

Hff.

Someone drew a sharp breath. I could feel countless emotions swirling among the guards who filled the stone wall.

Fear and anger, shock. And, last of all, confusion at not knowing what to do.

That confusion could mean only one thing.

Not all of them are Dark Heaven’s lackeys.

There were thousands of traitors on this battlefield alone. No matter how long the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had lived in the imperial court as Cang Gong, they couldn’t all have been raised as Dark Heaven’s dogs from the start.

The Great Nation’s imperial court wasn’t so easily fooled.

They were won over. Coerced. Or given orders they couldn’t refuse.

That was probably how Dark Heaven had brought them into line. Now I had their carrots and sticks in my hands.

“There’s one thing I can promise you, at least.”

I spoke up abruptly, then addressed all the Imperial Guards.

“If you side with the imperial court now, I’ll make sure you don’t end up as traitors, one way or another.”

As soon as I finished speaking, I reached out toward an Imperial Guard officer approaching from a blind spot, his killing intent unmistakable.

Whoosh. Thud.

A whistle cut through the air. One more corpse was added to the count.

I pointed at the body lying there, a Finger Qi hole through its brow, and added calmly,

“Anyone who doesn’t like my offer, raise your hand.”

“…!”

“…!”

No one raised a hand. I jumped down from the stone wall.

Of course, I didn’t forget one last thing I absolutely had to say.

“Oh, and if there’s someone you know is a real bastard, cut him down right now.”

“E-Excuse me?”

“Kill him. Do it yourselves.”

“…!”

That’s right.

From here on out, kill each other.

I left the Imperial Guards glancing at one another and ran toward the Fire Dragon Pavilion members fleeing the unknown black-clad figures.

To meet them.

To save them.

Whoooosh!

Chapter 909

“Hah… Hah…”

Hyuk Mujin was gasping for breath. His arms and legs, moving nonstop while he was on edge, creaked like they belonged to someone else. His heart felt ready to burst at any second.

How did it come to this?

Even as he ran for his life, Hyuk Mujin wondered when and where everything had started going wrong.

But as always, one question led to another, with no end in sight. At the end of it all, only one self-mocking thought remained.

Fuck. Was being born the mistake?

Hyuk Mujin felt so wronged and miserable he could have cried.

Why the hell had a textile-shop owner’s son insisted on becoming a martial artist? He could’ve quietly taken over the family business.

If he hadn’t read all those trashy books starring extraordinary martial artists as heroes, he might be like everyone else by now, with a family and two or three kids he adored.

At the very least, he wouldn’t be getting chased by a bunch of weirdos who’d appeared out of nowhere.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The pursuers’ heavy footsteps rang out behind him. A chill ran down Mujin’s spine.

Shit. If they catch me, I’m done for.

He didn’t know who they were or where they’d been hiding before they suddenly appeared, but one thing was certain.

Those bastards are like monsters. No—they’re monsters.

It wasn’t just a judgment of their martial arts.

The chill, the primal fear he’d felt from the moment he first spotted the black-clad figures, had only grown stronger with time.

What the hell… are they?

His mind was full of questions he couldn’t answer.

And his body, already pushed to its limit, was slipping out of his control a little at a time without him even realizing it.

Slip.

“…!”

His legs suddenly gave out.

Still moving too fast to catch himself, Mujin pitched forward. His eyes flew wide—

“Hyuuuuuk!”

Grab!

A thunderous shout rang out as a powerful hand seized his collar. Mujin, who had nearly slammed face-first into the ground, tried to calm his pounding heart and looked up.

Thump. Thump!

He saw the face of the giant—no, Taishan—running with Mujin tucked under his arm like a piece of luggage.

“Hyuk. You okay?”

Mujin barely managed to squeeze out a reply.

“No. Not even a little.”

“Yeah. You look that way.”

“…If you know, why ask? Are you messing with me?”

“Hyuk. Is that how you treat the person who saved your life?”

“No. Thanks, then.”

“If you’re thankful, pay me back with a hundred bowls of five-spice pork later.”

“I’ll buy you two hundred bowls, not just a hundred. For now, let’s stay alive. Alive.”

“Two hundred bowls?”

Taishan furrowed his brow and slowed down, muttering to himself.

“How much is two hundred bowls?”

Namho and the Divine Physician, perched on Taishan’s broad shoulders, and Mujin, now tucked under his arm, all screamed at once.

“What kind of lunatic does that? Why the hell are you slowing down all of a sudden?”

“Young Hero Taishan! This is no time for that!”

“What are you doing, you crazy bastard?”

But even amid their frantic protests, Taishan’s brow remained furrowed as he wrestled with the problem.

“I don’t understand. How much is the number two hundred?”

“Goddamn it…”

Namho groaned toward the heavens, then turned to look behind them.

The others bringing up the rear—and the black-clad figures right on their heels—were rapidly drawing closer.

“Just answer him! Looks like he’ll need an answer even if his head gets smashed in! Hurry!”

At the Divine Physician’s desperate plea, Namho shouted, his face pale.

“A hundred bowls! If you have a hundred bowls twice, how many is that?”

“Hmm. A hundred bowls twice is… Ah. Taishan understands now.”

At last, Taishan found his answer. He spoke with a triumphant look.

“A hundred and two.”

“You fucking bastard!”

“You goddamn idiot!”

“Ah, Master…”

Wails erupted all around them.

Namho, driven to the edge of his patience, brought his elbow down on Taishan’s thick skull. Mujin let out a sobbing scream. The Divine Physician thought of his absent master and fingered the large acupuncture needle inside his sleeve, wanting, for the first time, to kill someone.

But unlike the others, Taishan’s face shone like the midday sun. He’d worked out for himself how much two hundred bowls was.

“Two hundred bowls. A lot. Anyway, it’s a whole lot!”

Even a hundred bowls would be enough to eat until his stomach burst. And two hundred bowls!

Truthfully, he didn’t know the exact difference between two hundred and a hundred and two. But Taishan decided not to worry about such trivial details.

Then, grinning broadly, he waved both hands at someone who hadn’t heard the good news yet.

“Pavilion Master! Pavilion Master! Taishan gets to eat five-spice pork! Hyuk said he’ll feed me till I burst—a hundred and two? Two hundred? Anyway, till I burst!”

“Don’t worry about your stomach bursting. Before that, I swear to Heaven I’ll burst your head myself—Wait, what did you just say?”

Namho, who’d been hammering away at Taishan’s crown with all the persistence of the Foolish Old Man moving mountains, widened his eyes and looked up.

And saw him.

Namho saw him. So did the Divine Physician, Hyuk Mujin, and every Fire Dragon Pavilion member following behind.

Whoooosh!

Someone was rushing toward them with a fierce whistle of air. Familiar flames burst from his toes.

“Captaiiin!”

Mujin finally let out the tears he’d been holding back.

Life has a way of throwing things at you that make no sense.

For people who'd lived before the Great Cataclysm, it must have been the monsters and Hunters that seemed to drop out of the sky one day. For me, it was the world I'd come to know through the capsule.

The situation in front of me wasn't quite on that level, but it was still plenty confusing.

"Five-spice pork! A hundred and two! Two hundred!"

Taishan, his face alight with near-maniacal joy.

"Kill this bastard right now! You're more than capable of cracking this fucking idiot's head open!"

Namho, radiating so much rage that *mania* didn't begin to cover it.

"Waaah! Captain! Why'd you take so long?"

Hyuk Mujin, sobbing with the relief of someone who'd died and come back to life.

"Ah, Master… This unworthy Disciple had a wicked thought."

And finally, the Divine Physician, muttering with such a serene, transcendent expression that he looked ready to send even the Buddha flying with a Palm Strike of the Tathagata.

"…"

What the fuck?

I had no idea what was going on.

I stared at them, speechless for a moment, then gave up trying to understand.

Though it would be more accurate to say I didn't have time to make sense of it.

Pat-pat!

"Pavilion Master! No, Young Master Jin! No, Benefactor!"

Ju Hwaran came running toward me, somehow managing to address me by three different titles in the space of a breath. Her clothes were a mess.

Behind her, Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo swung their weapons like mad to keep their pursuers at bay.

Clang!

Slice!

Sword Energy flashed in the darkness, and what looked like blood sprayed through the air.

The wind carried an unbearable stench with it.

What's that smell?

Even from this distance, it made me frown and turned my stomach.

But I had no time to work out what it was. As the three drew closer, narrowly staying ahead of their pursuers, I moved my lips.

—When I give the signal, everyone get down.

I sent the Sound Transmission to each of them and gathered every last bit of internal energy in my body.

Shhhh…

I drew heat from deep within myself and sent it through every limb and acupoint.

My acupoints, still not fully healed, screamed. I felt the wounds I'd sustained in the fight, large and small, tearing wider. But there was no other way.

I have to do it.

Whummm.

The iron spear I'd taken from some nameless Imperial Guard just before jumping down from the stone wall trembled, filled with Scorching Yang Qi.

The spearhead glowed red. Blue-white flames spread over it, nothing like they once had been, but still too powerful to ignore.

And at last—

Fwoosh.

Hellfire surged around the spearhead, burning the air and devouring the darkness. It swelled toward the figures approaching in silence, without a scream or a shout.

Like a beast poised to charge a flock of sheep.

Hotter and more ferocious than anything else in the world.

—Now.

I sent the signal to the three and swung the spear with all my strength, as though to cut the world in two.

Like a dragon's tail stretching out without end.

The first form of the Blazing Flame Divine Spear.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Fwoooosh!

In that moment, all around us lit up as brightly as day.

Blue-white flames leaped from the spearhead and surged forward, burning and melting the ornaments scattered throughout the imperial palace.

They passed over the heads of the three, who'd heard my Sound Transmission and dropped down half a beat before the final moment.

Then they engulfed the vision of the black-clad figures close on their heels.

Kwaaaaaa!

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A tremendous explosion and roar. Then the earth shook.

Light flashed, and the swelling flames fell like rain, covering a radius of several dozen *jang*.[3392]

It was a sight worthy of the name *fire demon*.

[3392] One *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

And through the acrid smoke of that blazing inferno, where not even a scream could be heard, three people came running.

Pat-pat!

Ju Hwaran. Song Ilseom. Sama Pyo.

I spotted their familiar faces and gave a faint smile.

Or maybe it was my vision that was growing faint, tilting a little more with every passing moment.

Thump.

Making it look as natural as possible, and without anyone noticing, I straightened the spear and used it to support myself. Then I suppressed my labored breathing.

…Damn it.

Weakness crawled up my body like a living snake.

My internal energy, abundant despite its instability, had run dry. My body, which should've been resting, cried out in pain from the strain I'd put it through.

And on top of that came mental exhaustion I could barely bear.

I should've held back with the Middle Dantian as much as possible…

I knew well enough there was no point regretting it now.

If I'd held back more, I wouldn't be in this state. But there was no guarantee things would've gone any better.

For now, I could only be satisfied that I'd saved the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, who'd come back here for some reason, from the danger right in front of them.

"Benefactor!"

Ju Hwaran, now right in front of me, shouted with alarm written across her face.

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo came up on either side of her and spoke, their expressions strained.

"We all have to run."

"Right now!"

Their reaction was only natural.

My all-out strike had swept through the front ranks, but at a glance, more than a thousand enemies remained. I couldn't judge their individual strength precisely, but none of them would be easy to deal with.

Then the smoke began to clear. As the scene behind it slowly came into view, I finally understood.

Why they were so desperate.

And why Ma Sanbao had been so confident the rebellion would succeed.

"That's…"

A faint groan escaped my parted lips.

Chapter 910

They say even a dog at a village school can recite poetry after three years. Spend a few years working as a Hunter, and you stop batting an eye at most things.

The awful stench coming off a monster's body? That's nothing.

If you see blood spraying like a fountain and someone's limbs getting chopped off —not in a game or a movie, but in real life—

And if that someone is you or one of your companions… well, there's no need to say more.

First comes the fear of death, before you even set foot on a battlefield. Then you watch brutal scenes day in and day out until every nerve and sense begins to go numb. Only then do you become a Hunter in the truest sense.

That was how it happened for me.

But even I, with a fair amount of hard-earned experience under my belt, couldn't hold back the nausea rising from the pit of my stomach right now.

"That's…"

What the hell is that?

I couldn't bring myself to say the rest aloud. I had to clamp my mouth shut just to settle my churning stomach.

And I wasn't the only one.

"Ugh."

Ju Hwaran was the first to bend over, her face pale as she covered her mouth.

As heir to the Yongbong Escort Bureau, she'd had far more experience than other young prodigies her age. But compared to the rest of us, she still lacked real combat experience. Her reaction was only natural.

No, the fact that she hadn't thrown up was impressive.

Everyone here—including me, who'd fought my way through all kinds of hellish situations—was barely holding back a gag, our faces twisted.

"What… What is this?"

The Divine Physician muttered in a strained voice.

The old physician's eyes trembled with undisguised shock and the fear of someone who'd glimpsed something beyond comprehension.

Along with a sight before us that was impossible to believe.

Sizzle. Hissss.

Less than a dozen *jang*[3393] away, flesh burned with a sound we could hear. A horrible stench filled my nose.

[3393] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Amid the remnants of the flames and the blackened ashes, shapes staggered to their feet.

“Grrr… Gaaah.”

Their voices were neither screams nor words.

The black-clad figures—no, the *things*—let out strange, unrecognizable cries through melted lips and stumbled forward.

As though they couldn’t feel the slightest pain.

As though they didn’t even know what state their bodies were in.

Crack. Crumble.

Arms, legs, and other parts blackened by the Scorching Yang Qi that had swept through them broke apart and scattered as ash.

One of the things that lost its balance and fell tilted its head.

“Grr…?”

It looked as though it were asking why its body wouldn’t move. A shiver ran down my spine.

They’re moving? Even after taking a blow like that?

Of course, not all of them had been caught in my attack.

But the hundred or so black-clad figures at the very front had taken the flames pouring from my spearhead full on.

That terrible heat. That devastating strike made of Scorching Yang Qi.

I’d seen it with my own eyes, and everyone here knew what they’d seen.

That was why it was so hard to believe.

That should’ve killed them outright. No—there’s no way they should’ve survived.

My body might not have been in good shape, but I’d given it everything I had.

I’d poured most of my remaining internal energy into the strike. I’d been certain it would kill at least one in ten of them.

But I’d been wrong.

Before my eyes, nearly half of the hundred figures at the front were getting back up, trampling the ashes of what had once been their comrades.

And they looked nothing like creatures with any life left in them.

“…This is insane. What am I looking at?”

Namho had lived through the horrors of the Great Faction War. His groan spoke for everyone here—except me.

Or, to be more precise, at that moment I was seeing something else the others didn’t know.

How is this possible?

Death was fair to everyone.

A Supreme Peak master could be cut down by a weapon just like a Third Rate knife-fighter. Once your skin melted and your insides burned like theirs, you didn't get back up.

But they had survived.

They showed no sign of screaming, no agitation—not even the pain they should have felt.

This is…

That was when a word I desperately didn't want to believe came to me. It struck like lightning, then slipped through my parted lips.

"Undead…"

Not dead, but not alive either.

Supernatural beings who went on existing past death instead of finding rest. Monsters that should never have appeared in this world.

There was only one answer, and I knew what I had to do.

"Eom Dae-du? What does that mea—"

"Run."

"What?"

I looked at Hyuk Mujin, whose eyes had gone wide, and spoke to him and everyone else in a low, tight voice.

"If you want to live, run. Right now."

"…!"

"…!"

The next moment—

Rumble!

Through the ringing air, the smoke still hanging thick around us, and the blazing piles of ash, an army of the dead walked out and began to advance as one.

"Grrraaaaa!"

Their cries carried the chill of death.

For as long as anyone could remember, the Murim had fascinated the continent's gossips.

And why wouldn't it?

Another world, with borders and laws of its own—or rather, none at all.

A place where outlaws lived beyond the bounds of nation and citizen.

It teemed with righteous heroes, fiends, and people who, depending on the moment, might be neither. A mountain of sabers and a forest of swords, where even the greatest master could meet his death at any time.

So those who belonged to the Murim were scorned and admired in equal measure. And the gossips, who loved nothing more than a story, gathered everything they saw and heard and ranked its people.

That was how a book with the ridiculous title *Murim Ranking Record* came into being.

But no matter how many connections those gossips had or how keenly they listened, there was a limit to what they could know.

Who was stronger than whom?

Everyone named in the *Murim Ranking Record* was a formidable master. The closer you got to its last page, the more often you encountered those called superhuman.

Supreme Peak masters of the orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction, the Demonic Cult, or somewhere between orthodox and unorthodox.

Among them were wandering martial artists who roamed the Murim alone like lone wolves, heirs to mysterious and little-known sects, leaders of great powers, and people called Cult Leaders. Most of them shared one thing in common.

Nonaggression. A ban on fighting.

They didn't confront one another lightly, much less come to blows.

That was only natural when every one of them was a giant capable of moving the Murim. For the gossips, though, it was a disappointment.

If a life-and-death duel broke out between Supreme Peak masters, they'd learn for certain who outranked whom—and gain a rare story they could dine out on for the rest of their lives.

But conflict in the Murim didn't erupt so easily. For a long time, the last page of the *Murim Ranking Record*, where the greatest warriors' names were written, went unchanged.

Until the storm of the Great Faction War swept through some fifty years ago.

As if to mock those long years of peace, things no one could have imagined began to change.

One revered master died, then another, and another.

News arrived with every sunrise and sunset. The gossips nearly wore their brushes down recording it all.

But just as surely as the sun rose and set, new names appeared.

"Have a look at this. I think we've been given bad information."

"Bad information? That can't be right."

"Read it. It says a thousand Demonic Cult members were wiped out in Anhui. I can't see how it could be true."

"A thousand? That's quite a force. But why doubt it? Looks like the Murim Alliance finally dealt them a proper blow."

“It wasn’t the Murim Alliance.”

“What?”

“It says it was all done by one person. He wiped out a thousand Demonic Cult members alone, without anyone’s help. Not a single one was spared.”

“…What?”

The name Jeok Cheongang was first made known that way. A few years later, he acquired the title Fire King. By the end of the Great Faction War, which had shaken the world of the Murim, his name had made it to the last page of the *Murim Ranking Record*.

The Martial God and the Three Saints.

And among the ten Supreme Peak masters who followed them, he was the fiercest and strongest of the kings: the King of Kings.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

The man himself wasn’t proud of it in the slightest.

“*Murim Ranking Record*? The world’s gone mad. Do they give firewood grand names like that these days?”

The monk who’d brought him the news smiled at Jeok Cheongang’s indifference and sipped his suspiciously warm grain tea.

“Is that so? When I looked it over, I found it surprisingly accurate for firewood.”

“That’s just fools talking nonsense. Are orthodox martial artists the only ones in the world? There are plenty of strong fighters among those who practice demonic and heterodox arts.”

“Even so, in the orthodox Murim, you’re fourth. After the Martial God and the Three Saints. Quite impressive.”

“Enough of that nonsense. Pour this old man a drink. What did you brew it with this time?”

“Amitabha[3394]. You mustn’t say such things. This is grain tea, not alcohol.”

“Grain tea, my ass. You sound like you’re kicking the Buddha in the ribs.”

“Watch your mouth. Do you want to suffer in tongue-pulling hell[3395] someday?”

“Fine, fine. Give me a cup before I break that Green Jade Buddha Staff you’re holding. I don’t want to set fire to the Shaolin Temple at my age.”

“Ha ha! What a joke. Still, I’d wager that within ten years, you’ll overturn the order of this *Murim Ranking Record*.”

“Hmm. I probably will. I’m old enough that I could be dead within ten years.”

“…Amitabha[3396]. You say the most ill-omened things without a second thought.”

[3394] Amitabha is the Buddha of Infinite Light; invoking his name is a Buddhist devotional practice.

[3395] A Buddhist hell associated with punishment for liars and slanderers.

[3396] Amitabha is the Buddha of Infinite Light; invoking his name is a Buddhist devotional practice.

"I've lived long enough. I don't know when we'll meet again, but if you haven't heard from me in ten years, come to Mount Jiuhua and cremate my body. Scatter my ashes from the highest peak, if you would."

"Hm. You're more extravagant than you look. Asking the Abbot of Shaolin to come chant sutras for you."

"I don't need sutras or a fortunate rebirth in paradise. That's how I've lived."

"Then shall we make a wager?"

"A wager? On what?"

"Whether you'll surpass even the Three Saints in ten years, or die as you say. I'm betting on the former."

"…"

"Trust me. And in ten years, let's meet here and have another drink."

That had been a long time ago.

The ten years they'd spoken of had passed three times over. Jeok Cheongang had seen off an unworthy Disciple he'd taken in by mistake, and even the friend who'd sat across from him sharing drinks had returned to the earth.

Yet now, a memory he'd long forgotten came back to him.

The words Hong Dao, the Dharma King, had spoken with a serious face, though he was usually so quick to smile.

You'll surpass the Three Saints.

Boom!

His departed friend's faint voice didn't fade beneath the blast of air from a powerful Palm Force.

If anything, Jeok Cheongang heard it more clearly.

Trust me.

Shh-shh-shh-shing!

Wind sharp as blades whipped around him. But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's fierce attack—the pale-skinned old man's—didn't touch a single part of Jeok Cheongang's body.

To him, that felt entirely natural.

Ah.

Elation welled up from deep in his chest.

He had lived a hundred and several decades. All his life, he'd inflicted pain, suffered pain, and, for the first time, shared that pain with someone.

His advanced age. The Heart Demon that had filled his mind.

I thought this realm, which I reached by a stroke of fortune, was the furthest I could go.

Now he knew.

He had been wrong. His departed friend had been right.

Though I haven’t surpassed them yet…

“I’ll try.”

As the words scattered from the tip of his tongue, a faint smile formed on Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

At that moment—

Fwoosh.

A massive blaze unlike anything seen before struck the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord in the chest.

Chapter 911

He could feel it.

His body and mind were light enough to take flight.

Power welled up from deep within him, and the joy of having taken even a small step into a higher realm swept through Jeok Cheongang.

That sudden, modest insight was blooming into a greater, fiercer blaze.

Just as it was now.

Fwoosh.

A dazzling white flame flashed through the darkness, devouring and tearing its way forward.

Toward the enemy before him. Its heat filled the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's gray eyes.

"…!"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's eyes widened as a fist came crashing toward him, erasing the space between them.

What is this?

He knew instinctively.

The power in that fist was unlike anything in the countless attacks he had clashed with or evaded until now.

The great martial artist known as the Fire King had taken another step forward.

And for the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, that meant only one thing.

I can't dodge it.

At that moment—

Kwaaaang!

The earth shook beneath a roar that seemed to split the sky.

A terrifying tremor and the force of the impact swept outward. Through smoke and steam heavy with dreadful heat, a figure was hurled away.

Whooosh!

As the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's view spun amid the fierce rush of air, Jeok Cheongang stepped toward him. The impact had sent the Demon Lord flying like a cannonball.

Crack—boom!

He moved faster than sound.

Shooting forward like a streak of flame, Jeok Cheongang reached out.

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, brought to full mastery—or perhaps now beyond it—washed the space in white.

Bang!

The first strike broke the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's sword.

Boom!

The second barely grazed him and melted the ground.

Kaaa-bang!

The final, third strike slammed into the staggering Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's chest once more.

It shattered even the formidable Body-Protecting Qi that enveloped him.

Krrrunch!

The hard bluestone paving the grand banquet hall crumbled like tofu.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord hurtled away, his body smashing through more than ten *jang*[3397] of ground. Those who grasped what had happened in that instant moved at once.

"Kill him! Kill him!"

"The Demon Lord is in danger!"

"Stop him!"

Shouts rang out from every direction. Blades flashed.

But nothing could stop Jeok Cheongang now.

"Who dares—"

Crack!

"—stand in this old man's way?"

Boom!

No one reached Jeok Cheongang. No one could.

Blades gleaming with Sword Energy melted in the flames of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, while the Flame Divine Palm shot across the distance and swept through the approaching enemies.

"Urk—cough!"

"Aaargh!"

Those who mustered the courage to charge him head-on were the lucky ones.

Anyone who so much as touched the flames howled as they felt their own body burn alive.

Their screams became their last words.

Rustle. Thud.

After a brief but horrific agony, the dead sprawled like rotting trees.

Above the traitors' bodies, fused to their melted golden armor, flashed armor that had yet to lose its shine.

"Execute the traitors!"

[3397] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). More than ten *jang* is more than 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

“Long live His Majesty the Emperor!”

Shh-shh-shing! Slash!

Jeong Hogun cut down an enemy frozen by the unbelievable display of Jeok Cheongang’s power. Behind him, the Embroidered Uniform Guard charged over the traitors like a wave.

Clang-clang!

Thwack!

Weapons met, spitting sparks, and blood sprayed in every direction.

At the center of it all, the giant known as the Fire King pressed forward as he always had, smashing and burning everything in his path.

To end this fight.

To reach the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who was staggering to his feet behind the countless moths still rushing at Jeok Cheongang.

Boom!

Scorching Yang Qi, hot as lava, swallowed dozens of enemies.

The bluestone had lost its smooth sheen and melted into a ruin. Corpses burned like firewood amid the embers that remained.

As Jeok Cheongang approached, forging a path of fire no one dared block, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord spoke in a voice mixed with a sigh and admiration.

“You attained… cough. You attained enlightenment?”

Jeok Cheongang stopped a few steps away and stared at him without a word.

The Demon Lord was in a terrible state.

His beard, once white as an immortal’s, was soaked with blood. One arm and one leg were broken. His clothes had already turned to ash, leaving his chest exposed and blackened with burns.

Not even Hua Tuo[3398]—or a Great Firmament Immortal—could have guaranteed his survival.

Yet the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord kept giving short, dry coughs and speaking, as though it might ease the terrible pain for even a moment.

“The Three Saints are a thing of the past now. A fourth star has risen right here, today.”

Jeok Cheongang answered in a low voice.

“Call it whatever you want. I don’t care about things like that. But…”

Step.

He began walking again. White hellfire rippled over his body, ready to bring this brief, ill-fated encounter to an end.

“You know one thing, at least. The third Demon Lord is about to die.”

[3398] Hua Tuo was a physician of ancient China renowned for his medical skill.

Jeok Cheongang's gaze on the unsteady Eastern Heaven Demon Lord was cold and clear, unlike the energy he wielded.

He would take no chances. He would make certain of the man's death.

The members of Dark Heaven had demonstrated unbelievable abilities time and again, defying the laws of the world Jeok Cheongang had believed in for more than a hundred years.

But those encounters had been trial and error, not failure.

They had been steps toward something broader and higher.

Each time Jeok Cheongang survived an unpredictable turn of events, he gained experience and insight. Little by little, he grew stronger.

The old monster of Mount Jiuhua was still growing.

Just as his Disciple was.

Just as his close friend, now dead, had once promised he would.

"A certain bald monk said long ago that this old man would surpass the Three Saints before long."

Step.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord watched Jeok Cheongang approach with careful steps and smiled faintly.

"That monk was right."

"Yes, he was. Thinking back on it now, I wonder if that monk had some trick for reading the heavenly patterns… but I'll never be able to find out. Do you know why?"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord didn't answer. At the mention of reading the heavenly patterns, he had realized which bald monk Jeok Cheongang meant.

And Jeok Cheongang expected no answer.

"He's dead. Killed by you people of Dark Heaven."

"…Hong Dao, the Dharma King."

"If I'd been at Mount Jiuhua, I wouldn't have been this angry. There would've been nothing I could do about it."

But he hadn't been at Mount Jiuhua.

Hong Dao, the Dharma King and Jeok Cheongang's friend, had died at the Blood Lord's hands within the grounds of Shaolin Temple.

A place Jeok Cheongang could have reached in mere moments.

"That's how the monk died. By the time I got there, it was too late."

Jeok Cheongang had once been afraid.

Afraid that the damned infirmities of old age would return one day and erase even the last image of his dying friend. That they would make him forget the vow he had made while biting his lip until it bled.

"That day, I made a vow."

Step.

He took another step and went on.

“I swore I’d kill every last bastard bearing the name of Dark Heaven.”

Rumble, rumble.

The ground shook. The air boiled.

Energy hot enough to erase the very air—worthy of being called Extreme Yang, no, Extreme Flame—flowed from Jeok Cheongang’s entire body like lava.

It looked ready to swallow the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord at any moment.

“And today, I’ll send one more to the afterlife with my own hands.”

Five steps.

That was the distance between them, far too little to stand between either man and death.

“Save your last words for Yama[3399].”

At that moment—

Fap.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord pushed off with his foot. His body vanished. Nothing in his speed or movement suggested the man who, moments ago, had seemed to be waiting for death.

Shh-shing!

Jeok Cheongang reacted to the sound cutting past his ears.

Two rushes of air overlapped. No—three.

“Hah!”

Paaang!

The azure dragon’s roar shook the battlefield, the internal energy carried in Jeok Cheongang’s shout bursting the compressed air.

At the same time, two streaks of light shot toward Jeok Cheongang’s back as if guided by an invisible hand—then were knocked away.

They were the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s two swords, pulled toward him by the power of his Middle Dantian. Jeok Cheongang drew up energy from throughout his body, gathered it in both hands, and swung upward as though scooping from below.

Toward the sky above him. Toward the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, falling like a meteor.

Whoom.

Two currents of white energy, unmistakably alike yet astonishingly different, rushed toward each other.

[3399] Yama is the lord who judges the dead in Buddhist tradition.

To the two men, they moved slower than an ant. To everyone else, they moved too fast to see.

And the moment the two monsters struck with both palms, each using all his strength—

Kaaaang!

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

A blinding flash filled everyone's vision. A vast, terrifying force unlike anything before it burst outward, spreading in every direction. It swelled until it swallowed the sprawling grand banquet hall, already turned into a battlefield.

Whooosh.

The darkness disappeared. So did the unsteady torchlight, the people driving blue blades into their enemies, and the angry shouts they had been roaring.

No—more precisely, the flash and roar had blinded and deafened everyone for an instant.

…!

…!!

A white world where nothing could be seen or heard.

Those trapped within it forgot friend and foe alike, frozen in confusion. Only a tiny handful were exceptions.

Papapat!

Jeok Cheongang and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord charged at each other without pause.

Moving faster than sound, they deflected each other's attacks, countered, and charged again.

To the rest of the world, it all lasted but an instant. To these superhumans, who had cast off the limits of humanity, it was different.

In time that seemed to have stopped, they fought hundreds of exchanges and faced dozens of close calls, until at last they reached the end of their seemingly endless life-and-death duel.

Thwack!

Bone and flesh crushed, and one figure staggered.

But the fist piercing his chest and protruding from his back, wreathed in white flame, would not even let him fall.

"Truly… truly remarkable…"

His voice trailed off, drained of strength.

In Jeok Cheongang's deeply sunken eyes, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's shattered arms hung limp.

"If Yama[3400] asks why you died…"

[3400] Yama is the lord who judges the dead in Buddhist tradition.

Shunk.

Jeok Cheongang slowly pulled his fist free. Only then did the Demon Lord's body begin to crumple.

"…Tell him a friend of that bald monk sent you."

Thud.

Jeok Cheongang silently looked down at the fallen Eastern Heaven Demon Lord. Not a trace of life remained in the corpse.

Then, just as he let out the breath he'd been holding and turned away—

Crack.

A cold pain that should not have been there, a pain he could not begin to understand, swept through his entire body.

Chapter 912

Everything happened in a flash.

Jeok Cheongang sensed the sinister energy flying at him from behind. Alarm bells rang in his mind, and he twisted away.

But even instinct, faster than reason, couldn't help him fully evade the strike.

Crunch.

Hot. And cold at the same time.

The two opposing pains began in his side and spread through his body like wildfire, bringing with them a question he could not answer.

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang looked down, his eyes trembling, at something buried halfway in his side.

It had crushed flesh and bone, severing the vital points and internal energy within him strand by strand. It was a white hand.

Pale as a corpse's—or rather, the hand of someone who should have been lying dead.

"How could you… how could you…"

Jeok Cheongang lifted his head, forcing the words out. Before him was a face he should never have seen again.

"You were clearly… dead."

The owner of the hand, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, replied.

"Yes, I was."

Then he added, his voice calm as if nothing had happened, his expression showing not a trace of pain:

"But who in this world can lose his one and only life twice?"

"…What?"

Jeok Cheongang stared at him, eyes wide, unable to make sense of it. Instead of an answer, icy energy burrowed into his body.

Danger!

It happened almost at the same time.

Powerful Palm Force drove deep inside him, and Jeok Cheongang twisted away in a flash.

But caught off guard by the first blow, he couldn't evade this one completely.

Boom!

Jeok Cheongang bit his lip as his vision dimmed for an instant.

Kh.

The pain was intense.

He felt the Body-Protecting Qi around him scatter like smoke, and his body shot backward.

Whoooosh!

His vision blurred. The sky and earth flipped over and over.

Someone screamed. Fragments of whatever his hurtling body had struck flew in every direction.

A blow like that would have taken even a Supreme Peak master out of the fight.

But he was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

Crack! Bang!

He twisted in midair, righted himself, and landed on his feet.

Jeok Cheongang carved a deep furrow several *jang*[3401] long into the ground, absorbing the remaining force. Then his body suddenly staggered.

Hack.

Dark red blood spilled from between his lips.

Unable to hold back the congested blood that had risen with his internal injuries, Jeok Cheongang spat it out. That was when a faint whistle reached his ears.

Whoosh.

He couldn’t see it. But he could feel it.

A strike plunging toward his head. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord reaching out with a hand that shone an icy, glacial white.

Picturing the scene half a beat before it happened, Jeok Cheongang pushed off the ground.

Shwaaack! Boom!

In that sliver of an instant, the strike narrowly missed him. It cleaved through the ground like tofu, then exploded, leaving a huge crater.

A few Embroidered Uniform Guards nearby were unlucky enough to be swallowed up by it.

But the predator’s pursuit didn’t end when it missed its prey.

Swish.

The movement was as smooth as a snake’s.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord rose from the crater and stepped toward the retreating Jeok Cheongang.

Papap!

In an instant, he closed the distance between them. A dazzling, icy white light burst from his fingertips.

Fwoosh.

[3401] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Jeok Cheongang watched that brilliant, dreadful light swell and swallow the darkness. He gritted his teeth.

Crack.

A faint pain, then the taste of blood in his mouth.

At last his blurred vision came into focus. His dulled senses returned, making the pain from his internal injuries sharper, but he paid it no mind. He drew up the internal energy throughout his body.

Wooooong.

The air, chilled moments ago, grew hot. His torn meridians screamed.

The fire dragon inside him writhed violently, barely under his control.

As if it would burn even its master's body.

As if it would devour everything and reduce it to ashes.

And yet—

"I don't know what strange power brought you back to life."

Jeok Cheongang met the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's gaze without a flicker of hesitation. His voice burned like lava as he went on.

"But I'll put an end to that stubborn life of yours."

Even if he had to do it dozens, hundreds of times.

His closed lips held back the words he left unsaid. They could not hold back the several *jiazi*[3402] of Scorching Yang Qi surging through his body, setting every limb and meridian ablaze.

KWAOOOOO!

Amid a roar like a dragon's, light-flames and white light shot toward each other. At last, they collided.

At the center of that space, warped by an energy beyond anything seen before, they swallowed even Jeong Hogun's scream-like order to retreat.

Fwoosh.

And in the blinding flash that filled his vision, Jeok Cheongang heard a voice.

"Old Master!"

The next moment—

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The entire world—the sky and the earth—shook.

There are moments when it feels as if the world has stopped.

When the shock and roar shaking everything around you numb every sense.

That was how it felt to me right then.

[3402] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

"…!"

If the sun fell from the sky and landed right in front of you, would it feel like this?

Blinded and deafened by the flash and roar, all I could do was protect the people nearby as best I could from the enormous force about to hit us.

"Get down, ri—!"

I had no idea whether my frantic shout reached the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, or whether they'd dropped to the ground when they heard it.

I knew only one thing for certain: if they'd hesitated for even a moment, not one of them would still be on their feet.

KWAaaaaa!

Rrrrcrack!

The raging gale shoved me back. The ground heaved like a volcanic field, and bluestone broke into dozens, hundreds of fragments that flew in every direction like hidden weapons.

The corpses of those already dead went with them, along with the countless weapons that had lain scattered around like their gravestones.

Sh-sh-sh-shik! Thud!

"Aaargh!"

Someone's blood and screams scattered on the wind.

But I drove both feet deep into the ground and took the shock wave with my whole body.

Squeezing out what little internal energy I had left, I knocked aside or cut down everything flying toward us.

Pit-pit!

Even when small, thin fragments of blades and bluestone swept in with the gale and grazed me all over, I didn't care.

If I dodge, the others will get hurt.

If someone had to be hurt, it was a hundred, a thousand times better for that someone to be me.

Old Master must have felt the same way.

I'd seen him clearly at the last moment.

He'd heard my shout and suddenly shifted to block the direction we were heading.

KWAaaaaa…

How much time passed?

After what felt like an eternity, the roar and the shock began to fade.

One by one, the things the wind had hurled into the air fell back down. Sounds that had gone muffled for a moment began to reach my ears again.

"Ungh…"

"P-please. Save me…"

The groans of people from both sides, fallen in a tangled heap. Someone begging for their life.

And finally, familiar voices behind me.

“Is everyone—everyone all right?”

“Cough. I’m fine.”

“Taishan gritted his teeth and held on by thinking about two hundred plates of five-spice pork.”

“I’m really sorry to ask at a time like this, but can someone break that bastard’s teeth?”

I wanted to answer Namho, but my strength had given out. Even that was difficult.

I staggered, and two people hurried over to grab my arms.

“Benefactor—no, Young Master Jin—no, Pavilion Master.”

“Captain, are you all right?”

I told Ju Hwaran to pick one form of address and stick to it. Then I gave Hyuk Mujin a long look that meant, *Do I look all right to you?*

Only then did I see the undead army climbing over the stone wall several dozen *jang*[3403] away.

The Imperial Guards, who had changed sides to avoid being branded traitors, were now falling in droves as the monsters that had appeared out of nowhere tore into them.

Damn it. Maybe I should’ve lured them here after all.

I couldn’t help wondering whether we might have done some damage to them if I had. But there was no telling how it would have turned out.

Those things were undead, plain and simple.

Monsters that got back up even with their arms and legs torn off or their chests pierced.

But the word *monster* wasn’t reserved for things with grotesque appearances or strange powers.

People used it for anything that defied common sense.

And the man known as the Fire King belonged in that category, too.

Papap!

I pushed Hyuk Mujin aside when he tried to stop me and hurried toward Jeok Cheongang as fast as I could.

No—I tried to.

If not for the one thing Jeok Cheongang said next.

“Stand back.”

His voice was deeper than usual.

[3403] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

His entire body was covered in blood and soot, but he kept his eyes fixed ahead without even glancing at me, though I stood a few steps behind him.

At the lone figure standing beyond the slowly settling dust cloud.

And right then—

Fwoosh.

A breeze blew from somewhere, sweeping away the dust cloud. Beyond it, the figure came into view, walking slowly over countless corpses and pools of blood.

"…!"

I caught my breath without meaning to. Only then did I understand.

Why Jeok Cheongang had told me to stand back.

And why I hadn't sensed even the slightest sign of life from someone who, for a moment, had been right beside us.

"Impressive, Fire King Jeok Cheongang. Truly impressive."

Squish.

With each step, blood that had pooled to his ankles sprayed in every direction.

Arms and legs that had belonged to someone unknown bobbed in the blood as it pushed them along.

Yet none of it was as chilling as *that thing*.

"I very nearly died, you know."

Crackle. Sizzle.

The flames were still burning his face. Beneath it, the only part that had kept its shape—his lips—curved into a gentle smile.

Cang Gong—the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord—or rather, the man who could no longer be called human, was smiling.

Melted skin left the bones beneath it plainly exposed.

In a state that would have killed anyone made of flesh and blood several times over, he looked at Jeok Cheongang, then at me, frozen behind Jeok Cheongang's shoulder.

And then he spoke.

"You two seem very close, master and disciple. Don't you think?"

At that moment, a voice I'd thought I would never hear again reached my ears.

"Yes, Master."

"You're late."

"Forgive me. Your unworthy Disciple's training wasn't sufficient."

Another figure staggered to his feet as he answered.

Ma Sanbao pulled out the short spear I'd driven deep into his body and came toward us. Jeok Cheongang muttered:

"Master?"

“Why? Is that strange?”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stepped forward and continued:

“I once had a sect, too. A Master who became a parent to me, and countless Senior and Junior Brothers who became my family.”

“…You bastard. Don’t tell me…”

“But they all died. They bled and fell defending their sect’s home against an oppression that made no sense.”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord slowly turned his head. At the end of his empty gaze sat the Emperor, on a tall, ornate throne.

No—what lay there was a past long gone.

“Under the pretext of moving the capital, I had to lose them all.”

“…!”

“…!”

At that moment, I realized who he really was. Before he became the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord of Dark Heaven, before he became Cang Gong of the East Depot, where had he belonged?

Jeok Cheongang realized it, too.

“…The Maoshan Sect.”

The words slipped from his lips like a groan.

Crick. Crrrick.

At last, the army of the dead breached the stone wall and poured into the grand banquet hall.

Chapter 913

A sea of corpses and blood.

There was no other way to describe it.

Everywhere the eye could see, corpses lay strewn about and blood ran in overflowing streams.

This vast space had been built for imperial celebrations. Today, it was a battlefield where countless people killed and died. The Embroidered Uniform Guard under Jeong Hogun had finally put down most of the traitors, but they had no chance to savor their victory.

Instead, they stood back-to-back, afraid.

Their battle wasn't over.

Now they faced monsters far beyond the bounds of common sense.

Grrk. Grrrr.

A terrible stench smothered even the thick smell of blood.

Jeok Cheongang stood back-to-back with Jin Taekyung, watching the creatures surround them and let out cries no one could understand. Then he spoke.

"Let me ask you one thing."

"You can ask me as many things as you want for three days straight."

Jin Taekyung spat out the blood pooling in his mouth, picked up a spear and sword lying on the ground, and added:

"If those bastards are willing to wait that long, of course."

Of course, Jin Taekyung knew there was no chance of that happening.

Everyone's thinking the same thing.

The faces of the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and the Embroidered Uniform Guards, now standing back-to-back in a circle, showed the same feelings swirling inside him. And then Jeok Cheongang's subdued voice came from behind him, tense in a way he couldn't hide.

"The realm of immortals… Your homeland. Does it have things like those?"

Jin Taekyung answered without hesitation.

"Of course. Tons of them."

"Tons? Just how many?"

"Uh, Old Master, how many meals do you think Taishan's eaten in his life?"

"An awful lot, I'd imagine. Too many to count."

"I think so, too. Now imagine at least dozens—no, hundreds of times that many."

Understanding dawned, and Jeok Cheongang sighed.

"Fuck, that's a lot."

"Yeah. A fucking lot. Some lunatic must've accounted for different tastes, too, because there are all kinds."

"Damn it. That's no realm of immortals. It's the Demon Realm."

"Oh, that's a separate place. I think I told you about it before."

"…For fuck's sake. What kind of world is that?"

"What kind? A shitty one. But you know what?"

"What?"

"This place seems to be getting just as shitty as my homeland."

Jeok Cheongang was silent for a moment after Jin Taekyung answered. Then he spoke.

"Yes," he said at last. "I think so, too. I suppose I've lived too long, to see a miserable sight like this."

"Why say you've lived too long? Don't jinx it."

"Enough with the pointless worrying. I plan to live another fifty years."

"That's much better. Yeah. You'd better."

Jin Taekyung tried to sound cheerful, but a great weight had settled in his chest.

Damn it.

He silently surveyed the area. Familiar and unfamiliar faces alike filled his vision.

On every face, the whirlpool of complicated emotions they were feeling showed plainly.

Tension. Shock. Fear.

And a handful of courage, drawn with difficulty from beneath it all.

How many of them will make it out alive?

Jin Taekyung forced himself to erase the ominous question that had suddenly crossed his mind. Right now, keeping his attention on the enemy was all he could manage.

"I have waited a very long time for this day."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stood tall at the head and center of the army of the dead encircling the battlefield. He spoke slowly.

To everyone there.

No—to the Emperor.

"Today, in this very place, the Great Nation will cease to exist."

At that moment—

Shhhhh.

An inexplicable chill spread through the air.

Pale energy flowed from the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's entire body, seeping like smoke across the battlefield.

No. It was swallowing the battlefield whole.

A bell in his hand rang, and the energy moved to its rhythm.

Jingle.

The eerie chime rang clear, yet it reached the mind rather than the ears. It was more like a wave of energy than an ordinary sound.

Most people lacked the martial arts realm to make sense of it.

But that same wave was raising those who no longer lived.

By the time Jin Taekyung realized what was happening, he was already too late.

Thump.

“Old Master!”

“Stop.”

Jeok Cheongang grabbed Jin Taekyung by the shoulder as he was about to shoot toward the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, and continued in a sunken voice:

“It’s already too late.”

“…!”

Jin Taekyung’s eyes widened. The change that followed showed him what Jeok Cheongang meant.

Crick. Crrick.

The ground trembled. As the vibrations grew stronger, the pools of blood rippled and the air turned cold.

No. That’s not it.

Jin Taekyung swallowed a gasp. His trembling gaze fixed on the nameless corpse at his feet, which had begun to stir.

It isn’t the ground… It’s the corpses.

The thousands of corpses covering the battlefield were waking.

Returning to the world of the living, where they no longer belonged. Becoming something other than human.

“Hh…!”

“W-what is this?”

“Strike before they—before those monsters get up! Hurry!”

Thwack! Slice!

The air grew colder, and fear spread with it.

Spears and swords struck the corpses in a frenzy, but they would not stay down.

Amid the chaos, Jeok Cheongang remembered the legends of the Maoshan Sect, erased from Murim long ago. He looked at his Disciple.

“What do you call things like this where you live?”

Crunch!

Jin Taekyung stamped on the corpse beneath his foot and answered through gritted teeth.

"Undead."

Grrr…

A corpse with its throat split open lifted its head from a pool of blood. Jin Taekyung had crushed its spine, yet it still struggled to rise.

"They're monsters that aren't dead, but aren't alive, either."

Jeok Cheongang nodded.

The pronunciation was unfamiliar, but the meaning was similar.

Among all the sects and martial families under Heaven, only the Maoshan Sect had preserved tales of such monsters. *Undead* described them perfectly.

Monsters that aren't dead, but aren't alive, either.

When Jeok Cheongang had first heard those tales, he had dismissed them as nonsense invented by idle gossips.

It was simply impossible.

It defied the natural order ordained by Heaven—an utterly bizarre legend.

But now, that was no longer the case.

The unbelievable legend was before his eyes.

"…Jiangshi."

Jeok Cheongang murmured the word like a groan and reached toward the corpse twitching as it rose.

Fwoosh. Boom!

Despite his serious Internal Injury, his light-flames burst forth without dimming in the slightest. They ate through the flesh of the thing that had returned from beyond the river of death, burning its bones and organs.

Psssh. Splash.

Jeok Cheongang stamped on the remains as they crumbled to ash and dissolved into the pool of blood. Then he turned to his Disciple.

"What under Heaven could survive the Fire Gate Clan's flames?"

"…!"

"Burn them without end. If they won't die, burn them to ash until they do. Just as our sect's ancestors did."

Jin Taekyung stared at Jeok Cheongang with wide eyes, then replied with a deliberately serious expression:

"How did you know? That's exactly what I'm best at."

Master and Disciple smiled at each other at the same time.

Then they charged the corpses surging in from every direction.

One streak of flame. No—two.

The eerie bell kept ringing.

Jingle. Jingle.

KWAAAAH!

It was a clash between the dead and the living, like watching a boulder fall toward an egg.

GRAAAH!

Undead. Jiangshi.

Or perhaps something else entirely. The corpses shot toward the surviving humans from every direction, sharp and fast as spikes.

They weren't stiff or slow like jiangshi, nor were they weak like undead.

That was what made them so formidable.

Crunch!

"Hold the line!"

"For His Majesty the Emperor—!"

Clang! Slice!

Their cries of loyalty vanished beneath the din.

Thousands of corpses crashed into the humans' shieldlike circle. They moved as nimbly as they had in life, and their souls, caught by the sound of the bell, no longer feared injury or death.

Crunch!

"Aaagh!"

Crimson blood spurted like a fountain. Every scream wrenched from someone's lungs belonged to the living.

Sword Energy severed arms, cut through legs, and pierced chests. Still the dead rose and advanced, breaking down the human formation little by little.

They followed the bell as it rang faster and sharper, carrying out their master's command.

Jingle, jingle.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord walked forward slowly. Hundreds of the dead followed him, Ma Sanbao among them. At the end of their path rose a high dais.

No—the Emperor stood there.

"When the long and fierce age of warring heroes was drawing to a close, I was only thirteen."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord spoke in a singsong voice. His gray gaze drifted to the young king trembling beside the Emperor.

A boy barely in his early teens.

Even he, an old man and a monster who had ceased to be human, had once been called a boy.

“I was a sinner from the moment I was born. A sinner guilty of being born in an age of chaos—a sin that could never be washed away.”

The day his father, an ordinary farmer, and his two older brothers, both still in their teens, were dragged off to the battlefield, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord learned something for the first time.

Misfortune did not come only to those who had sinned.

Having no wealth, no strength, and no spear or sword with which to fight back was itself a crime.

“And yet the rulers who sent innocent people before spears and swords were not sinners. They were Heaven itself. Thousands, tens of thousands, died on battlefields of their making while they filled their bellies with rice and meat.”

The last blaze of that age of chaos was spectacular. Men who proclaimed themselves kings and Sons of Heaven fought hardest at the edge of the precipice.

Among the countless lives reduced to ash in that blaze were the young Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s father and two older brothers.

And his mother, raped and killed after she resisted the soldiers who came to conscript her thirteen-year-old son.

From that day on, the boy did not cry.

Even a year later, after the final victor—who had ended the age of chaos with the sharpest and strongest spears and swords—ascended the throne.

Not when a Daoist recognized the wandering boy’s aptitude, took him as a Disciple, and brought him into his sect.

There, he met his Master and came to know his Senior and Junior Brothers.

At the Maoshan Sect, he found laughter instead of tears. Happiness.

And within a few years, that happiness ended.

“Did you know?”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stopped walking. Then he asked his enemy’s descendant, who was looking down at him from hundreds of steps above:

“What your grandfather, Taizu, did to us?”

Jingle.

Chapter 914

Jingle.

At the clear chime, which seemed to ring inside his head, the Emperor was suddenly seized by a splitting headache.

The Maoshan Sect.

The name remained in his memory, however faintly.

He and every other prince had studied the art of ruling. They were expected to know the history of the Great Nation and the imperial family inside and out.

That history included the Maoshan Sect—or, more precisely, the event known as the “Maoshan Rebellion.”

> **Third year of Pyeongjeong.**
>
> When His Majesty Taizu declared Nanjing in Jiangsu the Imperial Capital, the treasonous Maoshan rebels opposed the decision, rallied their forces, and rose against him.

The court historians had given the event only a brief mention, but its repercussions had been considerable.

It was an open revolt against the first Emperor, who had emerged from the long, fierce age of warring heroes as the continent’s final victor and established himself as an absolute ruler with boundless power.

That was why he’d been more merciless than ever.

Taizu, founder of the unified dynasty, was as cruel as he was great.

The day the imperial court received word that the Maoshan Sect, facing the loss of its ancestral home after generations of inhabiting it, had gathered its forces to oppose the relocation of the capital, Taizu immediately ordered his troops to march.

Three days later, it had disappeared from the world.

The mountain they had risked their lives to protect was engulfed in flames. Everything connected to the three characters that spelled *Maoshan Sect* was hacked apart by wave after wave of soldiers and thrown onto the pyres.

Humans and livestock alike.

The living and the dead alike.

But…

The records were wrong. Someone survived.

The Emperor endured the pain stabbing through his skull and looked down the seemingly endless flight of stairs.

There stood the Maoshan Sect's last surviving root, gazing back at him. He had endured through the ages for this day alone, his eyes burning with the hatred of a man who had never once forgotten his grudge.

"I've always wondered why you wanted to destroy the imperial family and the Great Nation."

The Emperor slowly rose from his throne. The hem of his long, ornate dragon robe brushed the ground.

Swish.

He walked forward at an unhurried pace. Baek Yeon, standing beside him, blocked his path with a rigid expression, but the Emperor did not stop.

Step. Step.

One step. Then another.

The Emperor descended the stairs carpeted in crimson silk. The two men who had once been bound as ruler and subject drew closer to each other.

Then the Emperor stopped halfway down, and a quiet voice slipped through his cracked lips.

"So you betrayed the late Emperor—my father?"

"Betrayed?"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord laughed aloud at the abrupt question, though his monstrous face was twisted into anything but a smile.

"Who betrayed whom? I never gave you bastards my loyalty for even a single moment."

He had waited a very long time for this day.

How many nights had he lain awake, reliving his sense of betrayal and his thirst for revenge?

How many buckets of blood had he spilled mastering the martial arts manuals his Master had entrusted to him as the sect faced destruction?

The boy had chosen to become a eunuch as the surest way to bring down the impregnable fortress of the Great Nation. Then, one day after he had grown into a young man, an unwelcome visitor appeared with an offer.

"I bring you the words of the almighty and great Lord of Heaven."

And that day, the young man joined the demonic army.

"Do you still not understand?"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stared at the Emperor with cold, gray eyes.

"You're not the ones who were betrayed."

His father had often said that an age of peace and prosperity would come someday. His two older brothers had been dragged off to the battlefield as though they were captives, yet they had promised to return alive.

And their mother, who had lost her husband and two sons, had believed that at least her youngest boy—far too young to be on his own—would survive.

But she had been wrong.

Every last one of their hopes had been betrayed.

The boy had lost his entire family and barely survived a battlefield he'd been forced onto. Then the second happiness that had found him, almost like a miracle, was stolen away as well.

"You betrayed me first."

All of them.

"No—the whole world."

Jingle.

"You betrayed it."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's voice and gaze, both cold until now, seethed like molten lava.

As he saw it, he was the one who had been betrayed first. The common people had been betrayed. The whole world had been betrayed.

He had lost his family to the struggles of men dreaming of becoming kings and ministers. His Master and fellow disciples, who had become another family to him, had been hacked apart by countless spears and swords.

And there had been only one reason.

They had tried to protect the home passed down to them through generations, defying Taizu's decree that no martial artists could live near the Imperial Capital.

That was all.

"That is why you must die."

In the most miserable, most horrific way possible.

"For that one wish alone, I have endured and waited all this time."

It had taken many years for the boy to become a young man, the young man to become middle-aged, and finally for his hair to turn white. But those years had not been wasted.

The mask of Cang Gong that the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord wore was magnificent and powerful.

The East Depot's intelligence network stretched across the world, and few among the civil and military officials who upheld the Great Nation had no connection to him.

As both the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord and Cang Gong, he was second in power only to the Emperor.

He might not have worn a dragon robe, but he was another absolute ruler—second to one, above all others. Most of the court lay in his grasp.

Even the imperial family.

"I—or rather, we are…"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's voice boiled as he spoke to the Emperor looking down at him.

"The Great Nation."

"…!"

"…!"

The air around them froze. At the same time, the worn bell in the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's hand began to tremble wildly.

Jingle. Jingle. Jingle.

Sound like the wailing of ghosts spread in every direction.

Louder. Farther.

It crossed the vast banquet hall and reached the stone walls covered in the bodies of the Imperial Guards.

It was loud enough to raise those who already lay there in a pitiful state from the dead.

GRAAAH!

A roar that chilled the spine alone shook the night air. The monsters, now more ferocious and powerful, advanced in response to the sound waves ringing through their minds.

Toward the towering stairs. Toward the Emperor standing at their center.

And at the head of that surging wave of the dead was the man who had waited for this day alone.

"Now, let's see it through to the end."

He muttered the words as though making a vow to himself, then took a step.

No—he was about to shoot forward and tear the Emperor to pieces.

Then a voice pierced his ear.

"Stop."

"…!"

"I know what you're trying to do, but you'd better leave it at that."

Hummm.

The air shuddered.

There was clearly only one speaker, yet the voice came from several directions.

Six-Harmonies Voice Transmission—a technique even a Supreme Peak master would scarcely dare attempt.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord felt the terrifying internal energy behind it and bit down on his lip.

He remembered his bitter defeat more than a decade ago and fixed his gaze on the woman looking down at him from just behind the Emperor's shoulder.

So Gyo.

On the surface, she looked like nothing more than a beautiful, graceful woman. But he had suffered a crushing defeat once before because of her intervention. He knew exactly how much power was contained in that slender body.

He knew how much he himself had grown in the years since, too.

But there was one thing he still had no way of knowing.

“Who the hell are you, woman?”

So Gyo’s image was reflected in his darkened eyes.

An unknown superhuman whose identity had eluded even the intelligence networks of Dark Heaven and the East Depot.

The greatest enemy of his life, who had appeared without warning one day and left wounds on his body and soul that would never heal.

The grave Internal Injury she had inflicted on him had never healed, forcing him to turn himself into a jiangshi. Even now, he could not be sure who So Gyo was.

“Answer me. Who are you?”

If she were an agent of the orthodox faction, she would not have stood by while matters reached this point. If she were a master secretly raised by the imperial family, she should have appeared to stop him long ago.

But So Gyo was neither.

Gripping a weapon resembling a curved saber in each hand, she looked straight at him, her gaze untroubled.

She had cast off the black clothing that had once covered her from head to toe and freely released the immense power she had kept confined within her body.

Fwoooosh.

It was unmistakable. Overwhelming.

An unprecedented energy took visible form, rising in fine strands from all over So Gyo’s body. Her calm voice, at odds with the situation, rang out from all six directions.

“Well, I have my own circumstances, just like you do. I’m not sure I should tell you for free…”

Step.

She walked forward slowly, and her gaze turned cold.

“If you bite down on a sword and kill yourself right now, I might think about telling you.”

“…!”

“Oh. Would that not kill you anymore?”

Crack.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord clenched his teeth without realizing it. But having stopped, he found it difficult to take another step.

Why?

By now, he had achieved Great Completion in all of his sect's supreme techniques.

The Maoshan Sect's arts might have focused on sorcery, including the art of controlling jiangshi, but he had made even death his own and become a superhuman in a different sense.

And yet…

She's dangerous.

He knew it instinctively. If he moved carelessly now, So Gyo would get the better of him.

Even though he could no longer die or feel pain, his Qi Sense kept sending him warning after warning.

"Master."

His Disciple Ma Sanbao's low voice reached his ear, but the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord did not move. He stared at So Gyo without a word.

The aura he felt from her now was on a level with the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

Considering the full strength at his disposal, he still had a good chance of winning, even with the Emperor, Baek Yeon, and the Emperor's hidden guards against him.

Strictly speaking, he judged his own martial prowess to be half a step below the Fire King's or So Gyo's. But he and every soldier under his command possessed such horrifying tenacity that they could keep attacking as though each strike were meant to take their own lives along with the enemy's.

Even if their arms and legs were cut off, even if their chests were pierced, they would not stop.

Not until every living person had fallen.

Not until their enemies' bodies and the blood flowing through them had gone cold as ice.

If I capture the Emperor and Prince Shangshan—or kill that woman—this will all be over.

The battle to the death was not taking place in this hall alone. By now, the armies of the Great Nation, divided into two, would be fighting a bloody battle around the imperial capital, and his side would win.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord opened his tightly shut mouth.

"Go."

Jingle.

The worn bell, a divine artifact of the Maoshan Sect, gave a strange chime.

Rumble!

More than a thousand of the dead—the Great Nation's elite soldiers, once known as the Imperial Guards—charged across the banquet hall.

GRAAAAH!

As the shrieking army surged forward like a wave, two streaks of light burst toward it.

Shwaaah!

Brilliant light flashed.

At the same time, the overwhelming Force unleashed by Baek Yeon and So Gyo, the two superhumans who had stepped in front of the Emperor, crushed and smashed the flesh and bones of the dead.

CRUNCH!

The vanguard was pulverized in an instant. But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord knew what the two of them could do and was not the least bit surprised.

I expected this.

Humans were made of flesh and blood, and all were fated to die.

Even those called superhuman had limits. Their limits might be far beyond those of ordinary people, but they were human limits all the same.

I'll wait for an opening and kill them in one strike.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord moved forward, his gaze dark. With his Disciple Ma Sanbao on one side and a master of the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac, returned from the dead, on the other, he climbed the stairs now covered in rotten blood and shattered corpses.

Splash.

And at that very moment—

"Are you busy right now?"

The voice came from some distance behind him.

Only then did he realize that the howls of his followers, which had been ringing out far away, were beginning to die down.

Perhaps the limits he had assigned to superhumans were higher than he thought.

Swish.

He turned, his face rigid, and saw two men he had not expected to meet again so soon.

"Hey, ugly-ass big bro. If you're not too busy, make some time for me."

"Indeed. This old man will take very good care of you."

Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung stood there looking like men drenched in blood. They bared their white teeth and grinned.

They looked so much alike.

Chapter 915

"You got here fast. Much faster than I expected."

After a brief silence, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord spoke again, his gaze dark.

"Which means you'll die all the sooner."

His cold gray eyes moved between Jeok Cheongang and me—or, more precisely, over the wounds covering us from head to toe.

Damn. He's sharp as hell.

The smile I'd forced onto my face faded. I tried to ignore the pain coming from every part of my body and lowered my stance.

Jiangshi.[3404] Or undead.

I couldn't even decide what to call those things, let alone remember how many I'd taken down. I'd fought the monsters pouring in without end, then fought some more.

I swung anything I could get my hands on. When there was nothing to swing, I smashed them with my fists and feet.

If they'd been ordinary humans, it wouldn't have been this hard.

But they weren't.

Attacks that should have killed a person in one blow had to be delivered at least three or four times before one of these things could no longer fight.

It would've been a lot easier if I'd had enough internal energy…

Jeok Cheongang and I had both used up a considerable amount in the fighting. The Extreme Yang Scorching Yang Qi accumulated through the Fire Gate Clan's secret cultivation technique was the natural opposite of the death energy within the corpses, but we couldn't draw on it without limit.

Especially with an enemy as powerful as the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord still ahead of us.

"You both look exhausted. Why don't you turn back now, while you still can?"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord glanced over our shoulders.

"Before everyone you left behind is dead."

Clench.

My grip tightened around the spear before I realized it. He'd struck a nerve because he was right.

Jeok Cheongang and I had broken through one section of the encirclement to reach him, but plenty of monsters remained behind us. The Embroidered Uniform Guard led by Jeong Hogun and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members were fighting with everything they had.

[3404] A *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse in Chinese folklore, often depicted moving by hopping.

They numbered far less than half the enemy. And the enemy were genuine monsters that neither tired nor died easily.

Even so, we'd had to leave them behind. We'd judged this our only chance.

This battle won't end unless we take out the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

He'd raised the dead twice already. Nothing said he couldn't do it a third or fourth time.

And if that happened…

We'd die. All of us.

As time passed, our allies would die and the enemy would multiply. Reinforcements wouldn't change that, even if they arrived—and I didn't know when they might come, or whether the Emperor had prepared any at all.

But if we take out their leader, that changes things.

I'd lived as a Hunter before I ever became a Murim martial artist. I knew the fastest, most effective way to bring down an undead army was to eliminate the Lich who'd raised it.

The problem was time.

Fifteen minutes at most.

We had to take him down within that time. Any longer, and the gap Jeok Cheongang and I had left would be filled with our allies' corpses.

The result would be the same if the other front, where So Gyo and Baek Yeon were holding the line, collapsed. Defeating the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord before the balance between those two fronts tipped was the only way out.

But…

Can we do it? In that little time?

I couldn't shake the sudden doubt. I didn't know if we'd made the right choice.

Maybe the best we could do was save Prince Shangshan and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and escape this damn imperial palace. Maybe surviving—even if that was all we managed—was the right answer. The thought pierced me like an awl.

GRAAAH!

Clang! Cough!

The roars behind me that I'd tried to ignore came through clearly now, along with people's screams and the clash of blades. The sounds kept tearing through my thoughts.

Damn it.

I swallowed the curse rising to my lips and gripped the spear shaft until my hand felt ready to burst.

—You can do it.

"…!"

—Trust me.

Jeok Cheongang's Sound Transmission came as if he'd seen straight through my thoughts. To my surprise, my wavering heart grew calm.

That's right.

I can do this. No—I have to.

With the Old Master, with Jeok Cheongang, it's possible. Because I'm not alone. It's *us*.

Even if we're facing three Supreme Peak masters. Even if every one of them is a monster who's left humanity far behind.

I have to fight.

I have to take them down.

—Now!

At his forceful command, Jeok Cheongang and I stepped forward together.

Whoosh.

The distance vanished in an instant. As though we'd agreed on it long ago, we thrust out our palms.

Fwoosh! KABOOM!

A raging blaze devoured the air.

KABOOM!

It was unbearably hot. And terrifying.

As the fighting became a three-way battle, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord leaped clear of the flames. The situation brought a three-legged cauldron to mind.

Break even one leg, and the whole thing loses its balance.

The battle as a whole was certainly going his way.

So Gyo, the one he had to be most wary of, was tied down fighting well over a thousand monsters alongside Baek Yeon. The best the Embroidered Uniform Guard led by Jeong Hogun and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members could do was hold on.

But even among the three legs of a cauldron that would topple if any one of them broke, there was a most important leg.

That leg was the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord himself.

That's why they pushed themselves so hard to break through the encirclement.

Boom!

The first blow missed him. He evaded the second just as easily, calmly watching the two men charge.

They'd grasped the heart of the matter at once. Amid the chaos of fallen enemies and comrades rising again, they'd found his weakness.

But which of them had made the call—the Master or the Disciple?

Jeok Cheongang?

Or Jin Taekyung?

If it was the former, I'd expect nothing less of the Fire King. But if it was the latter... I see why that person wants him so badly.

Martial prowess far beyond his years. Composure that held in any situation, and the bold judgment to see straight to the heart of a battle.

The Great Nation's military, nearly a million strong, had plenty of fierce generals. Truly great commanders were rare.

Jin Taekyung had both qualities, though he was barely past twenty.

Does that person mean to have the boy fill the places left by the departed?

In the past few months, the Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had died. Other powerful figures remained, himself among them, but the strength lost with those two had to be replaced somehow.

For his revenge. For the great undertaking still ahead.

And to the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, Jin Taekyung looked more than capable of filling the gap they'd left.

His Master, of course, could not be allowed to live.

Jingle.

The bell rang as the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord flowed away from another attack.

Golden Ox Palace responded at once. He had been commander-in-chief of the Imperial Guards and a Supreme Peak master of the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac.

Whoosh!

A greatsword larger than most grown men cut through the air.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been pressing the retreating Eastern Heaven Demon Lord without pause, roared:

"How dare a bastard like you!"

At that moment—

Fwoosh! KABOOM!

The Force coating the greatsword, stronger than it had been in life, met the heat of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

No. The flames swallowed it.

Crack. KABOOM!

A faint sound, like something splitting apart.

Unable to withstand the tremendous power, the Force shattered along with the greatsword. The flames melted the dozens of fragments even as they hurled them back at the wielder who had dared challenge the Fire King.

Papat! Thud!

More than ten blood-streaked shards drove into him like flashes of light, shattering flesh and bone as they lodged inside.

The impact shook Golden Ox Palace's body. The blood left within him gushed out like a fountain.

Splaaat!

Any physician in the land would have taken one look at his wounds and pronounced him dead on the spot.

But Golden Ox Palace was no longer human. He had a cursed tenacity that kept him moving, and a mission he had to carry out no matter how many times he died.

—Kill the Fire King.

His master's command had been driven deep into his emptied mind. Engraved there by the bell, that single mission lent strength to his staggering corpse and sent him charging forward, heedless of pain he could no longer remember.

Just as it did now.

GRAAAH!

With his whites showing and a roar that made anyone who heard it feel fear, the commander of the Imperial Guards, once called Golden Ox Palace, shot forward. His broken golden armor gleamed, proof of the fame he'd earned in life.

Whoosh!

The wind buckled. The space between them vanished.

Even when the flames in his path melted his armor and flesh together, he didn't stop. Like an enraged bull, true to the name Golden Ox Palace, he charged with all his might.

Toward one man.

The giant known as the Fire King.

He would serve as his master's shield and carry out the order to bring that giant down.

Tssss!

Force surged over the handspan of blade that remained of his greatsword.

But Jeok Cheongang's keen senses detected another attack closing in from an angle.

"…!"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

As powerful as he was cunning, he had turned himself into a living monster to avenge his sect. Now he changed course and came at Jeok Cheongang like a flash

of light, alongside the other monster charging heedlessly through the flames of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Damn it.

In the slowed world, conflict flickered across Jeok Cheongang's eyes.

Less than one *jang*[3405] separated them. It was too late to retreat.

Dodge?

If he succeeded, that would be best. But if he failed and suffered an even more serious injury…

I'll die. No question.

It wasn't his own life Jeok Cheongang was worried about.

His Disciple was fighting not far away. Exhausted as the boy was, he was still driving Ma Sanbao back. Jeok Cheongang could not have been prouder of him.

If this old man falls here, it's all over.

That was why he couldn't avoid the attack bearing down on him. He had no choice but to meet it.

Even if he suffered an injury he would never recover from, even if he died, he had to win this clash. He had to give those monsters a certain death they could never overcome.

Yes. Only then…

The boy would live.

Fwoosh.

In the slow-moving world, a single flame blossomed beautifully.

I'll kill you. I'll kill you until you die.

The Fire King Jeok Cheongang thrust out both arms, unleashing flames fiercer than ever before.

KABOOM!

A deafening blast and a flash that filled his vision set time moving again. Through that shuddering moment came a streak of swordlight and a familiar cry.

"Old Master!"

Thud!

Hot blood fell.

[3405] One *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to about 3.03 meters, or 9.94 ft.

Chapter 916

It happened in an instant.

In a sliver of time split and split again, it all began and ended like a passing flash of light.

Thnk!

Jeok Cheongang heard it clearly. He saw it, too.

A chilling sound of something being pierced reached his ears. At the same moment, something sticky splashed across his vision, staining it red.

Drip. Splaaash.

The world before him stopped.

Everything was red. The blood covering his face was hot.

And… it hurt.

More than anything ever had.

Why?

The hollow question that rose in his mind faded away.

No—perhaps it was Jeok Cheongang's consciousness that was fading.

His mind struggled to grasp a sight that should never have happened. Pain and emotion boiled up from his chest, driving him into a confusion and rage unlike anything he had ever known.

Slide.

He was falling. Tilting.

In the slowed world, a familiar figure was slowly flung away, his back to Jeok Cheongang as scarlet blood sprayed from him. The sight burned itself into Jeok Cheongang's wide-open eyes like a brand.

"…!"

The Fire King Jeok Cheongang understood. He accepted it.

Everything unbelievable unfolding before his eyes was real.

He understood what the second Disciple he had taken in late in life meant to him.

And that he was not the only one who felt this way.

Thump.

His hand reached out through time as it flowed slowly, supporting that familiar back.

It was firm and warm.

Like the heart of the Disciple who had thrown himself forward with all his might to save his Master. Like the blood spilling from his torn-open chest.

You foolish, foolish boy.

Jeok Cheongang had lived for well over a hundred years. Across the vast land, he had seen countless kinds of people, watched them rise and fall, and found the path he meant to walk among them.

He had walked it one step at a time, always decisive, never hesitant.

But even he did not know what to say now.

What could he say to the fearless fool who had thrown himself into Force in his Master's place? To the unfilial Disciple who dared to leave before his Master?

There was only one thing he knew he had to do.

He could not let the moment his Disciple had bought with his life go to waste. And he had to trust in the boy's stubborn vitality—the boy who had survived every kind of hell as if by miracle.

You have to survive. No matter what.

With that plea the boy could not hear, the old Master made the flames still burning in both hands flare fiercer.

Tssss.

The air burned. Moisture evaporated.

And within it, time began to move again.

At the end of that moment—

Fwoooosh!

A vast blaze swallowed even death.

Hummm.

Everyone saw it.

No—they took it in with all five senses.

They watched space warp in the terrible heat. Pain filled their muffled ears, and they trembled at the sudden terror borne on the scorching air and wind.

There was not a single exception.

The living and the dead alike.

Even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who had watched wide-eyed as So Gyo tirelessly cut down the charging monsters and Jin Taekyung fell spraying blood, felt a chill seize his spine.

No. It was heat, as though his insides were melting.

This…

He understood instinctively. This strike held something that internal energy alone could not explain.

The old Master's grief and rage had drawn out a power even he had not known lay dormant within him.

I'll die.

The fear of death awoke—a fear the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had forgotten, one he had believed he would never feel again.

Killing intent, deeper and more terrible than what he had felt facing So Gyo over a decade ago, surged toward him.

Toward him and everyone else.

"Ru—"

And in that instant—

KABOOOOOM!

A tremendous roar swallowed his cry, and a pillar of white-hot fire shot forth.

CRACK! RRRRUMBLE!

The fire dragon thrashed, melting the ground and burning everything in its path.

Surging forward like a wave, it filled their vision and greedily devoured everything its enormous body touched. It burned and vaporized it all, as if determined not to leave a single drop of moisture behind.

Blades lying where their owners had dropped them. Impossibly hard bluestone. Even the soil and rock beneath it.

Even bodies that had once transcended death.

KABOOOOOM!

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord saw it clearly. He heard it without a doubt.

Golden Ox Palace, reborn as one of his followers—a Supreme Peak master formidable enough in life to be counted among the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac—was engulfed in white flames.

And he heard his dying scream.

GRAAAAH!

Impossible. How could someone who no longer felt pain scream like that?

How could he writhe so desperately?

How…?

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stared in shock. At the same time, he felt the Extreme Yang heat, fierce enough to burn away even his soul.

At its center, he saw one man's eyes glowing red.

"You shouldn't have touched my Disciple."

The Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

ROOOOAR!

The fire dragon roared loudly enough to shake the entire Imperial Capital. Hearing it, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord prepared to die and drew up every last scrap of strength he had.

He blamed the subordinate who had been so damned faithful to his orders that he couldn't stop, and blamed himself for bringing about the touch upon the reverse scale[3406] of the dragon called the Fire King.

But…

It isn't over yet.

Not his life. Not the revenge he had pursued for more than half a century.

Fwoooosh.

The deathly energy of the dead closed around the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's body. The flames breathed out by an old, weary dragon crashed over it.

KABOOOOOM!

I don't know.

How much time had passed. How much time I had left if I was going to die here.

My senses had dulled and my vision was blurred. Neither told me much.

The ground shook as if there'd been an earthquake. A roar kept pounding against my muffled ears.

And then there was the heat.

It was hot. My body lay sprawled beyond my control, but I could feel that heat more clearly than anything else.

Old Master's really pissed.

I wanted to cackle, but what slipped between my trembling lips was sticky, and it wasn't laughter.

Cough.

Blood. Dark red blood with little clots in it.

I felt around my mouth, touched something soft and squishy, and paused to wonder.

Was that my lip? Or a piece of my insides?

…Damn it. I know which.

I let out a small sigh.

It was sad that I could even say this, but it wasn't the first time.

One strange, almost galling thing was that I'd never been this badly injured back when I was an F-rank Hunter.

Of course, getting stronger is the only reason I'm still alive.

I scraped together enough strength to lift my head. Dust and ash filled the air. With the aftermath still hanging over everything, all I could see was my own body.

[3406] In Chinese lore, a dragon's reverse scale grows against the others. Touching it provokes the dragon's wrath.

Wounds covered me from head to toe.

And my chest… Force had torn through it, leaving flesh and bone horribly exposed.

Cough. Cough.

I coughed up blood again. This time it was darker still.

Proof that the sword strike I'd taken earlier had reached more than my flesh and bones. It had hit my internal organs, too.

That was insane.

Yeah. It had definitely been insane.

Something I wouldn't have done if I'd been thinking straight. No—even a reasonably crazy bastard wouldn't have dared try it.

But I did.

I had to.

How was I supposed to just watch?

If I hadn't thrown myself in at the last moment, even turning my back on Ma Sanbao, Jeok Cheongang would be lying here instead of me.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord wasn't just a sorcerer who commanded the dead. He was an incredibly skilled fighter, and even Jeok Cheongang couldn't have taken him and another Supreme Peak master at the same time.

Part of me had hoped it might work, though.

To the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, I wasn't just an enemy he had to bring down. I was someone the Lord of Heaven wanted.

So much for taking me alive. He just went and stabbed me.

I laughed, coughing up bloody foam.

I'd gambled my life and lost spectacularly.

Now here I was, sprawled like a corpse, feeling my senses slip away one by one as I waited to die.

But I could laugh because I was the only one who'd lost this gamble.

My life alone wouldn't decide the outcome of the much bigger gamble playing out on this battlefield.

Some would lose and pay with their lives. Others would win and survive.

I was one of the former. That was all.

Regrets?

I'd be lying if I said I had none.

But I knew the state of my body better than anyone. No—maybe what I felt was just human instinct.

Death.

I could see it.

The thing that had already taken a father from my family—the unwelcome visitor I'd narrowly avoided through every danger I'd faced—had finally come for me.

Even now, through my fading vision, a black shape seemed to waver amid the falling ash and dust.

Don't come.

I tried to squeeze out a voice with all my strength, but all that came from between my lips was a little blood and a ragged breath.

I didn't give up.

Clinging to a consciousness that seemed ready to go out at any moment, I swallowed the blood pooling in my mouth and forced myself to stay alert.

I was afraid. Of death.

Afraid of leaving everyone like this.

There was still so much I had to do. So many things I wanted to do with the people I loved and who loved me.

But, but why?

Why was that shadow coming closer to me?

Why wouldn't it stop walking, even now?

I wasn't ready yet. I didn't want to die like this.

Just a little longer. Even for the briefest moment.

Gasping for breath, I begged it to wait.

Even if it took me after that, I wanted time to say goodbye. I prayed desperately to see, just once more, the faces of the people whose lives had become bound to mine. My family.

I prayed to a god I had never seen.

No.

To the System.

"Please…"

And in the moment those words escaped me, wrung from the last of my strength—

Ding.

A clear chime that only I could hear rang out across the whole world.

Chapter 917

Fwoosh.

A fierce gale roared through the air. Layers of black ash that had piled up across the ground, along with embers that still hadn't gone out, rode the wind and scattered in every direction.

From within the pale haze that blocked everyone's view, a flame-wreathed fist cleaved through the air.

BOOM! KABOOOOOM!

Compressed air burst apart. White flames surged beyond the superheated air.

Nothing could stop that fire.

It was a dragon's breath, its roar, its rage beyond measure.

The old dragon's flames poured over the enemies who had dared touch his reverse scale, burning more fiercely than ever before.

Fiercely enough that someone who had become nearly immortal found himself thinking of *death* without realizing it.

Ah.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord let out a quiet groan.

His gray eyes, filled now with fear and awe, remained fixed on the man advancing through the flames he ceaselessly unleashed.

Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King.

Him.

Only him.

Of the ten Kings who had never reached that lofty heaven, the foremost—the Emperor of Fire—was finally spreading the wings he had kept hidden and soaring upward.

Toward the three stars adorning the heaven called the Martial God.

All while pouring out his rage at the enemies who had touched what they should never have touched.

Rumble.

A tremendous impact hammered the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's entire body.

The death energy surrounding him without a single gap shuddered beneath a palm strike of unprecedented power. His legs, driven into the ground with ten thousand *geun*[3407] of force, carved deep furrows as they slid backward.

BAM! BAM! KABOOM!

One advanced.

[3407] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (about 1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,000 lb).

The other could only retreat.

Jeok Cheongang was the former. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord was the latter.

Like a sinner huddled beneath divine punishment, he dodged the thunderbolts that fell without pause.

How? How in the world…?

How could that exhausted body, already covered in wounds great and small, wield such strength?

How could he feel such rage?

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord swallowed the sigh rising to his lips.

Jeok Cheongang approached with an overwhelming aura, his anger so fierce the Demon Lord felt he could reach out and touch it. And he found that he understood.

He had felt the same.

BAM!

He had lost his family.

BAM!

He had lost his sect.

BAM!

When he thought he had lost everything, he discovered something still remained in a corner of his emptied heart.

Rage.

They said humans were human because they could feel joy, anger, sorrow, and pleasure.

They said living beings could laugh, rage, grieve, and take pleasure in life.

But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had lost three of those things.

With only rage remaining, he had finally given up being human and become a monster.

A monster called a vengeful spirit.

That was why, in one respect, he understood Jeok Cheongang—the heart of an old Master who had seen his Disciple on the brink of death.

He understood, too, the rage held within that mighty flame, which was trying to burn even the death energy he had summoned with all his might.

KABOOOOOM!

In that instant, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord felt it.

The death energy encircling him had finally reached its limit.

For this moment, Jeok Cheongang's rage had surpassed his own.

Crack.

The sound announcing a rift reached the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's ears. The energy that had poured ceaselessly from deep within his body was scattering.

At the starting point of that rift was a fist wreathed in pure white flames—and a pair of eyes pouring out stream after stream of fire and an even greater heat, flames that would bring down his last line of defense.

"Understand this clearly."

Jeok Cheongang's gaze seemed hot enough to turn anyone it met to ash.

"Understand what you've touched."

Yet his voice was as cold as the glaciers of the North Sea. It froze the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's spine and seeped into his soul.

It awakened the fear he had forgotten long ago, on the day he rose from death.

Hah.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord trembled despite himself. A hollow laugh escaped him.

And suddenly, he understood.

Perhaps the Three Saints… or even beyond.

At least for this moment, nothing could stop the old dragon's rage.

Nothing.

CRASH!

At last, the barrier split and shattered.

As everything surrounding him broke to pieces, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord thrust his fist toward the white flames flooding his vision.

Whoosh!

A movement faster than sound.

The dead clashed with the living.

In a world turned pure white, the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist advanced as if in slow motion and met the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's fist.

No.

It swept right through it.

BAM!

An instant of contact. A tremendous boom.

But the time their fists met was far too brief, and the balance of power had already tipped.

Crack.

Heat swallowed the scattered death energy and mangled his skin. It melted his acupoints and sinews, then shattered his bones.

The stronger body and regenerative powers the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had gained by giving up his human life were useless.

KABOOOOOM!

Jeok Cheongang's fist was lava and lightning at once.

True to the name Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, the flames he unleashed shot forward, reducing everything in their path to ash.

They swallowed the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's fist, then his entire arm.

Fwoosh. BOOM!

The flames erupted at their peak.

But no blood burst forth. There were no scraps of flesh, not even fragments of bone.

All of it had vaporized or turned to ash. It was gone beyond recovery unless time itself could be turned back.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord knew it better than anyone.

So did Jeok Cheongang.

Step.

Jeok Cheongang took a single stride, and the space between them folded.

Thrown backward like a misfired cannonball, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord gritted his teeth and twisted his body.

Crack. BAM!

A fist grazed his side—if pulverizing a handspan of flesh and bone could be called a graze—and slammed into the ground.

At the same time, a tremendous boom split the sky, and a massive crater opened in the earth.

A chill ran through the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord. He felt as though every hair on his body stood on end.

If he could feel pain like an ordinary human, if he had fought Jeok Cheongang as he was now, how long would he have lasted?

How many times would he have died?

This is…

He had thought himself immortal. Unless the Martial God, who had vanished long ago, returned, he had been confident no one who came for him could bring him down.

He had been wrong.

If I can't dodge, I'll die.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord wanted to live.

Even if he had died once already, he wanted this life to continue.

At the very least, he had to bring down the Imperial House, heir to that loathsome bloodline, and the Great Nation that was Taizu's achievement and legacy.

He could not fall before his revenge was complete.

For his family and the members of his sect, who had met such horrific deaths.

And for himself—the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who had chosen to become a monster for the sake of this day.

I. I…

Grind.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord clenched his teeth. With no blood left to spill, bits of flesh fell away instead.

I cannot fall. Not ever.

Even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord himself couldn't tell what it was.

Was it the rage that had carried him this far? His obsession with revenge?

Or the last surge of fighting spirit from a martial artist facing the greatest enemy of his life?

Only one thing was certain.

Just as Jeok Cheongang had before him, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had surpassed his former limits.

Whoosh!

In the blink of an eye, Finger Qi streaked across the space between them like lightning and pierced Jeok Cheongang's neck.

No—it only looked as though it had pierced him.

Jeok Cheongang had been charging at him like a streak of flame. For an instant, it seemed he would fall with blood spraying from his pierced neck—then his figure dissolved like a heat haze.

"…!"

Shifting Form and Position.

At the instant those four characters flashed through the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's mind, he spun around and swung the bell clutched in his only remaining arm.

Whoosh!

The bell slashed downward with a fierce whistle, gleaming with death energy.

A single blow. If even one strike landed cleanly, no one could come away unscathed.

That was how battles between Supreme Peak masters called superhuman were fought.

And the Fire King and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord were monsters whose martial prowess could not be fully expressed even by the words *Supreme Peak*.

But—

Crack.

That strike was not enough against someone who, for this moment at least, had reached a new realm. One he might never reach again, even if he lived past today.

Was that all you had?

Jeok Cheongang had neither spoken aloud nor used Sound Transmission.

But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord heard it clearly. He saw it, too: the unspoken words in Jeok Cheongang's blazing gaze and tightly closed mouth as he stared at him, one flame-wreathed hand gripping the bell.

At the same time, he saw his own arm engulfed in flames in the next instant.

Fwoosh! KABOOOOOM!

A wildfire on a mountainside might burn for days. The Scorching Yang Qi summoned by its master's will did not.

Its dreadful heat flared in an instant and faded just as quickly, melting away the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's last arm without a trace.

But the enraged Master's punishment did not end there.

CRACK!

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's vision shook.

As his arm vanished, a fist smashed into his side. It crushed flesh and bone, then poured flames into his organs, long since rotted away.

No!

Each blow Jeok Cheongang landed brought death another step closer.

SHWAAAA!

Half the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's upper body had been scorched black by the previous attack. He didn't resist the force throwing him backward.

Instead, he poured every bit of energy remaining into his still-intact legs.

He had lost both arms and the bell. He had to put as much distance between them as he could.

But as he kicked off the ground with all his strength, he felt a force of ten thousand *geun*[3408] seize his ankle.

Crack.

Flesh was crushed. Bone shattered.

And at the same time—

Whoooosh!

The world turned upside down. Through the rushing wind, the ground surged up to meet him.

KABOOOOOM!

A thunderous roar drowned out his ears, and the earth's crust surged upward.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord lay buried deep amid shattered dirt and rock, in earth that had hardened like granite. His eyelids trembled.

This is…

[3408] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (about 1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,000 lb).

For well over half a century, he had worked in the shadows of the Imperial Palace and seen countless Supreme Peak masters.

So he knew.

This wasn't a matter of speed or strength.

Jeok Cheongang now stood in a realm beyond his.

Rumble.

He felt not the slightest pain. That made the sensation all the clearer.

One of his two remaining legs had just been torn off.

And that meant only one thing.

There's nowhere left to retreat.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord gave a hollow laugh.

Was that the smile of a man finally accepting the death before him?

No.

It was the bitter laugh of someone who had waited so long for revenge, but had been forced to choose between that and his life—and who had decided to reveal the hidden sword he had meant to draw at the very end.

"—Come out, Heaven's Slaughter."

And just as a faint line of Sound Transmission, its meaning unclear, slipped between his moving lips—

Shiver.

The empty air wavered.

An assassin dropped through the drifting ash and embers. The old man, whose limp gave no hint of his speed, shot forward like a flash of light and slashed a dagger down at the crown of Jeok Cheongang's head.

Whoosh!

The ambush was nearly perfect. No—it was perfect beyond dispute.

Just as it was about to succeed—

SHWAAAA!

A spear cut through space like a streak of flame.

Chapter 918

Whoosh!

In the slowed world, the old man plunged down like a flash of light, dagger in hand. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord knew instinctively.

It's over.

The ambush was that perfect.

Even the Fire King Jeok Cheongang as he was now could not evade it. No—he was angrier than ever, his composure gone, which made evasion even less likely.

Even if he somehow blocked or dodged the strike and escaped death, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord judged that he could not escape severe injury.

The limping old man he had called Heaven's Slaughter was one of the finest assassins in the Central Plains, comparable even to the Slaughter Saint.

I kept that sword hidden for the Emperor.

It was bitter, but there was nothing to be done.

The grand plan was already on the verge of falling apart. Survival came first now.

No matter how long it took or what means he had to use, he had to finish his revenge with his own hands. He could not die until he had watched with his own two eyes as the imperial family, heirs to that cursed bloodline, was wiped out—and offered a memorial rite for his Master and fellow disciples, who had met untimely deaths.

But if he was ever to resume that revenge, he first had to bring down the monster before him.

The Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

That monster rampaging like a fire demon sweeping across a boundless plain.

Die.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord was certain Jeok Cheongang would die. At the same time, he desperately hoped he was right.

Just as the old man's dagger—its blade dulled by a coating of ash and charged with Force—was about to cut Jeok Cheongang in two—

SHWAAAAK! BOOM!

A sound of something piercing the air rang out from somewhere and reached the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's ears. It drowned out every other sound as it tore furiously through the air.

His eyes flew wide. A blue-white flash had reached its destination before its sound did, filling his vision.

What is that…?

A spear of a common, unremarkable design—the sort one could find anywhere.

But the light upon it shone as brightly as the sun overhead, and its heat, hotter than the sun itself, burned even the air as it raced onward.

Toward Jeok Cheongang.

No—to be exact, toward the old man falling above his head.

"…!"

"…!"

"…!"

At that moment, everyone's movements stopped. The world they saw stopped with them.

Jeok Cheongang, who had only just noticed the assassin. The old man plunging down at him like a bolt of lightning. And the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, watching it all unfold.

Shwoosh!

They all watched the spearhead cut slowly through the air toward them. They felt the power within the blue-white flames coiling around it.

And at the same time, they understood.

Who owned that spear.

Where that horrifyingly intense Scorching Yang Qi came from.

Before the three-syllable name that had suddenly surfaced could even take shape in their minds, the spearhead had raced forward, erasing the space between them, and reached its destination in an instant.

At the last possible moment, the old man frantically turned his dagger to block the spearhead bearing down on him.

Whoom—KABOOOOOM!

Blue-white flames swelled as they met the Force surging from the dagger. A thunderous boom shook heaven and earth, and the shockwave lashed out in every direction.

KRRRACK!

The earth shuddered as if struck by an earthquake. Wind whipped about madly.

In that muffled world filled with nothing but ash, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord finally pieced together one man's name and screamed it like a wail.

"Jin Taekyung!"

At that moment—

Fwoooosh.

The hazy world split apart.

A man drenched in blood from head to toe approached, moving more lightly and swiftly than ever. He bared his white teeth in a grin.

"Don't say my name. I might get attached."

Then he shrugged toward one man standing dazed and motionless at the feet of the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who was sprawled there, stiff as a statue.

"Looks like this bastard still hasn't come to his senses. Should I pull out his tongue while I'm at it?"

"…"

"Old Master?"

The Fire King Jeok Cheongang, his old Master, didn't answer.

No—he couldn't answer.

He gazed in silence at his Disciple, who had come back as he always did. Then he burst out laughing, so delighted that tears ran down his face.

At the same time, he felt all the anger and sorrow that had held his whole body in its grip come crashing down, and he grasped his Disciple's arm tightly.

"Thank you."

Grip.

"For coming back. For coming back like this."

"…!"

The corner of Jin Taekyung's eye, caked with dried blood, trembled.

Thank you. For coming back.

A few words, but they were enough.

He felt the warmth of his Master's hand on his arm and the sincerity in every syllable.

That feeling was more than enough.

There was no need for them to say anything more.

This brief reunion between the two men who carried on the Fire Gate Clan's lineage would soon mean death for their enemies.

That was how the Fire Gate Clan had survived for three hundred years. It was also the way of these two, bound as Master and Disciple by an inexplicable connection.

Smash and burn everything in our way.

Whatever it is.

Without fail. No matter what.

Step.

Master and Disciple moved forward together. Beyond the unsettled dust and ash, sticky killing intent crept toward them and wrapped around them.

Whoooosh!

The limping old man, Heaven's Slaughter, blended into the darkness and quietly waited for his moment.

Even as he watched his subordinates die less than a dozen *jang*[3409] away, there wasn't a trace of agitation in his cold, sunken eyes.

Whoosh. Slice!

Before the blade dulled by ash could even reach its target, a head sprang into the air.

Anyone who saw those men crumpling like straw dummies would find it hard to believe that each was an elite assassin he had spent at least thirty years training.

I thought I could take down even the Three Saints with those children.

No—perhaps he really could have.

His ambush moments earlier had been that perfect. He could have erased the giant known as the Fire King Jeok Cheongang from this world himself.

If not for the unwelcome visitor who had appeared out of nowhere.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

Heaven's Slaughter swallowed the groan that threatened to escape him.

It wasn't only because his broken wrist throbbed. It had snapped when he deflected that spear, so full of power, at the last moment before his ambush succeeded.

So the real monster wasn't the Master…

He had seen it clearly from the darkness.

Jin Taekyung falling with an injury beyond recovery. Coughing up blood mixed with pieces of his organs, with the shadow of death stirring at the edge of his life.

And yet, how could he possibly…?

Those who roam the martial world with death for a companion are martial artists. And among them, assassins stand closest to death.

Heaven's Slaughter knew that better than anyone.

Since early childhood, when he had been trained as an assassin, he had killed people with his own hands in every way he could. The weight of those deeds had brought him to death's threshold, too.

If Dark Heaven hadn't helped me, this old man would have turned to a handful of dirt long ago.

Heaven's Slaughter's survival had been a miracle. But even that seemed insignificant beside what Jin Taekyung had just done.

There was no doubt. Force had pierced straight through Jin Taekyung's chest.

It had split flesh and bone, destroyed his acupoints, and seeped into his organs, tearing them to shreds from within.

[3409] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3410] Yama is the ruler and judge of the dead in Buddhist tradition.

No one could recover from such an injury—not even under the care of a Great Firmament Immortal, or if Yama[3410] himself erased their name from the book of the dead.

And yet Jin Taekyung had come back alive.

Though he looked like a man drenched in blood, his exposed skin was smooth, and his perfectly formed Muscles and Bones—the reason he was known as having a Heavenly Martial Physique—were plain to see.

And that wasn't all.

His formidable internal energy—several *jiazi*[3411]'s worth, an impossible amount for someone barely past twenty—had filled back up as if nothing had happened.

As if someone had filled an empty teacup with water.

As if it were only natural.

This is… something I can't explain.

An ability beyond reason.

Heaven's Slaughter's sunken eyes trembled faintly.

Now, his composure—barely held together until this moment—had finally crumbled. He was truly torn between two choices.

Flight and duty.

And he wondered who would kill him: Dark Heaven or Jin Taekyung.

Several decades ago, when he had been gasping at death's door, Dark Heaven had made him an offer he could not refuse. It had never been out of kindness.

A blade forged by Dark Heaven.

A human butcher who moved only at Dark Heaven's command.

That was the new identity Heaven's Slaughter had accepted in exchange for his life. A shackle he could never break, no matter how far he ran.

If he abandoned his mission and fled, punishment was all that awaited him.

Pain and death so terrible that even he, after a lifetime of killing, could not imagine them.

He could not hide. He could not escape.

That was Dark Heaven—or rather, the Lord of Heaven.

Heh. Heheheh.

Heaven's Slaughter laughed without a sound.

What a fool he was, agonizing over a question whose answer had been decided from the start.

There had never been a choice to make. Only one path lay before him.

Kill or be killed.

Heaven's Slaughter moved quietly through the darkness.

[3411] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; here it measures accumulated internal energy.

He silenced his breathing and erased his presence. Watching the elite assassins he had painstakingly raised with Dark Heaven's help get slaughtered, he slowly approached Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung.

Just one. If I can take down either of them, I can survive—even if I fail the mission and flee.

The grand plan had already gone awry.

But if he brought back something of equal value—if he brought back the Fire King Jeok Cheongang's head—he might be given another chance.

A chance to pursue his own unfulfilled revenge. A chance to keep this stubborn life going.

And, to his great fortune, even the heavens, usually so indifferent, seemed to be on Heaven's Slaughter's side today.

Whoosh! Whoosh! Slice!

Another life vanished with a piercing sound. But unlike Jin Taekyung, who was rampaging as if possessed, Jeok Cheongang looked utterly exhausted to Heaven's Slaughter.

Patapat. Splurt!

Hidden weapons came flying from every direction, grazing Jeok Cheongang's body. Then, after killing with a single palm strike the assassin who had dropped down from above, the old dragon exhaled raggedly through his lips.

Huff. Huff.

His lips were dry and tinged pale blue. His body trembled faintly, even as he continued to unleash attacks of terrifying power.

At the sight of Jeok Cheongang, who seemed to have forgotten the fearsome martial prowess he had displayed only moments ago, Heaven's Slaughter muttered to himself.

He's reached his limit.

In a way, it was only natural.

Jeok Cheongang had already surpassed his limits against the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, and even before that, his body had been covered in wounds large and small.

That opening was Heaven's Slaughter's only chance.

This strike will end it. No matter what.

Heaven's Slaughter calmed his mind. He erased even his killing intent—the energy anyone about to kill would carry.

No one harbors killing intent when slaughtering livestock instead of a human being.

He had spent his life as a butcher called an assassin. Now he shot straight forward with all his might.

And at that same moment, he understood.

Though he himself was still cloaked by his concealment technique, he saw Jin Taekyung staring straight at him. He felt that gaze pierce his entire body.

He knew from the beginning…

Puhk.

A blazing flame pierced his chest.

Chapter 919

There are two main ways a predator hunts its prey.

It can chase its prey down—or make the prey come to it.

The first is simple. The second is difficult.

But for all its difficulty, the second is more likely to succeed. Luring prey right up to you means you've made it lower its guard.

Or…

You've made the prey mistake itself for the predator.

One thing was certain.

The man struck by my spearhead as it flashed through the air belonged squarely in the latter category.

Puhk!

The gruesome sound of pierced flesh announced a successful hunt, and the air rippled.

Where only ash and dust had been swirling, an old man quivered like a fish skewered on a harpoon. I hadn't even seen him appear.

"Wha—how…? Cough!"

Drip. Drip.

Blood spilled from his mouth, running down his chin before he could finish speaking.

I looked at his face, twisted with pain like a fiend's, and answered calmly.

"I saw you. Clear as day."

"That's impossible. It can't be."

The old man gasped for breath. The assassins—now barely a dozen—rushed in from every direction to save their leader.

Like moths throwing themselves into a flame, knowing they would burn.

But the ending of this short story had already been decided.

From the moment I opened my eyes to the sound of a clear bell.

And from the moment Jeok Cheongang showed weakness to lure in prey that might flee at any moment.

Boom!

The heat of the Flame Divine Palm warped the air.

When the predator known as the Fire King swung his flame-cloaked claws, the moths fell without even a dying cry.

Rustle. Thud.

The last assassin, his upper body charred black, dropped to his knees.

There was no need to check. He was dead.

With his last hope extinguished right before his eyes, the old man's voice sank into an oddly calm murmur.

"So you showed an opening to lure in your target. You have more of an assassin's nature than I expected."

I made a show of frowning.

"That sounds like a compliment, but somehow it feels like an insult. Every assassin I've ever met has been trash, except for one."

"I suppose so."

The old man gave a tiny, spasmodic nod and continued.

"Mungyeong. Is that bastard still the same?"

"What?"

My brow furrowed before I could stop it.

Mungyeong was the Slaughter Saint's real name.

Fewer than five people in the entire world knew that.

Maybe even fewer.

Even counting me.

"How do you…"

"You're asking how I know that name?"

The old man coughed up blood again. "How could I not? He told me himself."

At that moment, I thought I knew who the old man was.

A few months ago, while I was in Sichuan, the Slaughter Saint had mentioned Salcheonmun in passing. It was one of the few things he'd revealed about his otherwise shrouded past.

"Salcheonmun."

Once, it had been the most feared assassin sect in the world.

Then the dagger it had forged—the Slaughter Saint—brought about its destruction. Now it was a remnant of the past, forgotten by most.

At the name, the old man nodded and smiled faintly.

"Make sure you tell Mungyeong this."

A fierce light flashed in the dying man's eyes. Blood poured from his lips, and his voice was thick with killing intent.

"Tell him we—Salcheonmun—will come for him. No matter the sacrifice, no matter how many years pass. We will come."

Hmm…

Judging by that, it definitely wasn't a reunion for Salcheonmun's twelfth class.

The kind of reasonable, beautiful ending where they meet up, polish off a few bottles of Jiannan Chun, call a designated driver, and ride home in a carriage wasn't something the assassin world did.

Especially if the Slaughter Saint himself had brought about Salcheonmun's destruction.

First the Maoshan Sect, and now Salcheonmun.

I'd thought something was off from the moment I first saw him.

The chain of gratitude and grudges went on and on, no matter how far I dug. I let out a small sigh.

"How thoughtful of you to give me advance notice. Don't worry. I'll pass on what you said word for word."

I looked the old man straight in the eye and added, "I'll tell him Gye Yabu of Salcheonmun said it."

"…!"

The old man's eyes, which had seemed ready to close, flew open.

His calm acceptance of death vanished. His voice burst out with a spray of blood, full of undisguised shock.

"How—how do you know that?"

"I told you. I can see."

"…What?"

Instead of answering, I jerked my chin toward the space above his head.

Floating in the empty air was a translucent roster that no one but me in this world could see.

> **Lv. 140 Gye Yabu**

The difference was simple.

The old man—no, Gye Yabu—possessed concealment techniques bordering on the miraculous. I had the System, which was a miracle in its own right.

And that difference had made Gye Yabu the prey.

"Goodbye."

With that farewell to end our brief encounter, I twisted the spear shaft in my grip.

Crunch.

White Flame, the weapon I had finally reclaimed, cut through bone and flesh like tofu and reached his heart.

The flames clinging to its transparent blade seeped inside.

Boom.

A small explosion made Gye Yabu stagger.

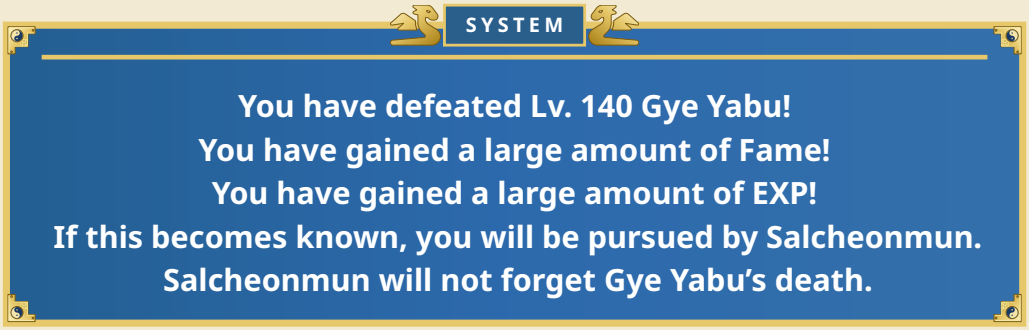
Dark-red blood poured from his seven apertures.[3412] He looked like a candle caught in a typhoon.

[3412] In traditional East Asian usage, the seven apertures are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

Puhk! Splurt!

I pulled out the spear and turned away. As I walked off, leaving his crumpling body behind, the bell I'd been waiting for rang in my ears.

Ding.



The System notification told me two things.

First, that Gye Yabu hadn't been lying when he spoke before he died.

Second, I'd grown strong enough that killing a Level 140 enemy wasn't enough to level me up—and that a warning about becoming Salcheonmun's target didn't bother me.

Though it does feel a little ominous.

I could just kill them coming or going.

I didn't know how skilled Salcheonmun's human butchers were, but I already had the Lord of Heaven's undivided attention.

How much hotter could a jalapeño really get if you added a Cheongyang chili?

I'd just have to drink a nice, cold glass of milk first.

Living milk packed with EXP instead of calcium. Enough to put an end to this damnable fight.

"Sorry I'm a little late. Get bored waiting?"

Step.

I stepped into the path of someone crawling away, scrabbling with the only leg he had left intact.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord confirmed it was me, then smiled through his twisted face.

"Yeah, you monster."

Those who failed despaired.

They wept and sank into misery.

But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord did not.

He neither despaired nor wept. He did not give up.

His revenge wasn't over yet. Hope remained.

His grand plan had failed, but he was still alive.

Even if a branch breaks, the tree doesn't die.

As long as its roots remained, the tree would not fall. Someday, it could grow thick branches and fresh leaves again.

Just as everything from the Maoshan Sect, destroyed by Taizu long ago, had passed down to him.

That was why he struggled.

With just one leg, his undying body squirmed as he tried to escape.

Not yet. It's not over yet.

Golden Ox Palace was dead. Ma Sanbao had disappeared, and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord didn't know whether he was alive or dead.

And there was more.

He had lost the means to control the jiangshi, and the Salcheonmun assassins, including Gye Yabu, were dead.

But if that was all he had prepared for today, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord would never have begun this grand plan.

I need time. Time.

It had been half a century since he infiltrated the imperial court as a eunuch.

The shadow of Dark Heaven that the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had cast over the Great Nation was deeper and larger than anyone imagined.

There were commanders leading armies of tens of thousands, admirals commanding fleets, and political heavyweights who could wield enormous influence with a few words or a handful of hastily written lines.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had more than satisfied their greed. In return, they had sworn loyalty and willingly climbed aboard the same ship, bringing everything they possessed: strength, influence, authority.

The great rebellion meant to overturn the Great Nation was not confined to the grand banquet hall.

That was why the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord could still smile.

Why he could smile even as he faced a monster greater than himself.

"Sorry I'm a little late. Get bored waiting?"

Step.

The voice was light, as though greeting an old friend. But the footstep blocking his way was heavy and firm.

Jin Taekyung.

The face of one man crossed his mind, then appeared in the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's vision.

"Yeah, you monster."

And at that moment—

Crack!

With a gruesome sound of crushed flesh, his only remaining leg was smashed to pieces.

Now deprived of all four limbs, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord calmly addressed another opponent through pain he could no longer feel.

“The world would be astonished to learn that the Fire King, famed for his rough ways, cares so deeply for his Disciple…”

CRUNCH!

A thunderous impact drowned out the rest of his words.

Then, as the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord was driven deep into the ground, a voice reached his ears, growling like a beast.

“Shut your mouth. Before I rip out your tongue.”

“My tongue? You’d rip out my tongue?”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord gave a short laugh.

“That’s not a bad idea. It would be a new experience for me, too.”

“You bastard!”

“My ears are ringing. Stop shouting and try it. Right now.”

“…!”

“What are you waiting for? I said, rip out my tongue.”

But no answer came, no matter how often he urged him. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s smile deepened.

“Right. You can’t. You won’t. If you rip out my tongue here and now, you’ll never get the answers you want.”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord already knew.

In a desperate fight for their lives, they might have killed him. But now that they had won, they could not.

He knew a great deal about Dark Heaven and the Lord of Heaven. One word from the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord could change the course of a Great War that would decide the future of the world.

A war that would put hundreds of thousands, perhaps millions, of lives at stake.

That was the last hope he clung to.

“Listen, Fire King.”

Rumble. Rumble.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord felt faint vibrations through the ground, growing stronger by the moment, and burst into hearty laughter.

“It seems Heaven hasn’t abandoned me after all.”

At that moment—

CRAAASH!

With a roar that shook the earth, thousands of soldiers poured over the shattered outer wall.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord laughed aloud.

No—he was about to.

Gooooong.

Until an enormous beam of light shot from somewhere, wrapped around them, and burst.

KABOOM!

Faced with that unbelievable power, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes flew wide.

At the same time, he screamed one person’s name.

“So Gyo…!”

Chapter 920

It all happened in an instant.

At least, that was how it felt to the East Depot masters charging at the vanguard as they scrambled over the rubble of the collapsed outer wall.

Fwoosh.

What in the world was this?

How could anything be so fast—and so destructive?

A dazzling flash filled their vision. For a moment, they could only stare. It was the last thing they ever saw.

KABOOM!

A tremendous roar battered their ears. An irresistible force swept over their bodies, frozen like stone statues.

Crunch! Fwoosh!

The flash vanished as quickly as it had come. One of the East Depot eunuchs charging behind his comrades blinked.

When his vision finally cleared, he understood.

That flash had been Force fired by someone.

That terrifying energy had swept away dozens of his comrades—and taken one of his arms, too.

“A-ah. Ahh. Aaaaaah…”

His jaw trembled. A dazed moan slipped between his teeth as they clattered without pause.

They were dead. No—they’d been butchered.

His eyes took in what remained of the men who had once been his comrades: chunks of meat so mangled he could no longer tell who was who. His mind struggled to accept the sight.

Only then did pain reach him from his shoulder, left in shreds as though a beast had torn into it.

“GRAAAAH!”

A scream of agony poured from his gaping mouth.

But he wasn’t the only one caught in shock and pain.

“Ugh… Uuugh.”

“P-please, save…”

“Ugh—bleurgh!”

Some groaned as they clutched the stumps of their severed legs. Some pleaded desperately for help on the brink of death. Others bent over and vomited at the carnage before their eyes.

They trembled, terrified by the gruesome deaths they'd witnessed and helpless to do anything.

Those who realized what had happened a moment later were little better off.

"W-what is this…?"

Some of the Imperial Guards, long since recruited by the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord and drawn into the rebellion, and the East Depot eunuchs who had led them into the grand banquet hall were struck speechless.

One strike.

A single strike had killed or incapacitated more than fifty soldiers.

Each had charged at the vanguard without hesitation, and each was a formidable fighter, ranging from Supreme First Rate to Peak.

Compared to the full force of some three thousand, it wasn't a major loss. But everyone had stopped because that one attack had swallowed dozens of Peak masters in its terrifying power.

No—it was the master behind that attack, whose might seemed almost demonic, who had stopped them.

Who…?

Who was it?

The question pierced everyone's mind.

The three thousand rebels who had surged into the grand banquet hall.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard and Fire Dragon Pavilion members fighting the dead, who refused to fall no matter how many times they were killed.

Even the dead, driven still further out of their minds when the bell was destroyed, stopped at some instinctive warning.

Then they turned their heads.

Toward the source of the flash.

At the end of countless gazes stood someone, trampling the twitching limbs of the dead.

Whoosh.

A breeze stirred the woman's thick hair.

"So Gyo…!"

In the silence that had fallen over the hall, a cry like a scream rang out belatedly.

The woman—no, So Gyo—lifted her head and looked toward the voice.

More precisely, toward the person standing there.

Jin Taekyung.

Her lips moved without a sound, and her dark blue eyes grew solemn.

The hundreds of steps leading up to the dais were already buried beneath countless bodies.

The thousand or so dead had been torn to shreds and finally died—or lay there writhing with their limbs severed.

As if hoping someone would put an end to their stubborn lives.

Slice.

A streak of light cut through the air.

The man who had split in two a dead man crawling up the steps on his one remaining arm lowered his sword and breathed hard.

Huff. Huff.

His entire body, soaked in blood and sweat, heaved.

His golden armor and sword, as intricate and splendid as works of art, felt heavier than ever.

No—perhaps it was the weight of the responsibility and guilt he had carried all this time.

And yet… he had no regrets.

He must not.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard who had turned to ash here today had also been prepared to die.

To pity them for a sacrifice they had chosen would be an insult worse than death.

Even if he was the most exalted man beneath the heavens, the one who stood above all others.

“Baek Yeon.”

The man—the Emperor—spoke, his voice rough with a metallic rasp.

He turned to the imperial court’s foremost military commander. Baek Yeon had done more than anyone to protect the late Emperor and the imperial family, and whenever the Emperor faltered, Baek Yeon’s harsh rebukes had lifted him back to his feet. He was more a comrade than a subject.

So the Emperor gave him a request, not an order.

“Sound the drum. The war drum.”

“…!”

Baek Yeon’s eyes trembled.

Taking in the Emperor’s exhaustion, his fatigue more visible than ever, he bowed deeply and extended a palm toward the great drum that had announced the start of the banquet.

Boom!

The drumbeat, charged with profound internal energy, rang out without end.

It carried the heart of a warrior who had waited so long for this day. It carried the Emperor’s will.

Once.

Then once again.

The sound was immense enough for everyone in the grand banquet hall to hear. No—it rolled like a wave that might sweep across the entire Imperial Capital.

Booooom!

Even when the third drumbeat rang out, the three thousand rebels didn't know what to do. They hesitated.

It had all unfolded so naturally.

So Gyo's overwhelming display of martial power had abruptly swept through the vanguard, and the drumbeat resounded with a grandeur they couldn't explain. For a moment, they had been overwhelmed before they even knew it.

Even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord—the instigator and center of the rebellion, who should have been leading them from the front—lay in a horrific state at Jin Taekyung and Jeok Cheongang's feet.

What is this? What in the world is happening?

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had been captured. Ma Sanbao was nowhere to be seen.

The Imperial Guards and East Depot leaders who had betrayed the imperial court and the Great Nation to join Dark Heaven looked at one another in confusion.

When they took the Outer Palace, they had thought it was all over.

Even when they had seized every gate leading into the imperial palace and defeated the remaining defenders, taking advantage of another allied force sweeping through the capital, they had been certain a new age was about to begin.

But the reality they had so eagerly come to meet was different. The battle should have been theirs already.

The flags that had flown so proudly when they first stormed into the grand banquet hall now fluttered as uneasily as their hearts.

And at that very moment—

Boom. Boom.

Another drumbeat reached their ears.

Every hair on their bodies stood on end. A chill ran down their spines.

The fourth drumbeat was no louder than the ones before it, nor did it have a deeper, more resonant ring.

Yet it made the rebels' hearts sink for one reason alone.

Behind them.

The sound came not from Baek Yeon, visible in the distance, but from somewhere behind them.

And then it spread in every direction.

Boom. Boom-boom.

The countless drumbeats spread like flames across a wide plain. They were not echoes bouncing back from somewhere. They were not a trick of the ears.

They were the signal that this long and gruesome banquet was coming to an end—the footsteps of hunters closing in on prey caught at last in a trap.

Rumble.

How long had this been going on?

Where had such a vast army been hiding, and why had it waited until now?

A trap!

The realization struck like lightning through their skulls. At the same time, the rebels felt immense tremors drawing closer.

Then they saw them.

Hundreds of flags rising high on every side.

Following the fluttering flags, a dragon embroidered in golden thread writhed as though alive.

"…!"

"…!"

Shock, joy, and despair swept across the grand banquet hall.

Some were seized by an elation so intense their hearts felt ready to burst. Others clenched their teeth until they bled.

The three thousand rebels were the latter.

Thousands. Or tens of thousands.

No one could guess the exact number of their enemies, but one thing was certain: the forces tightening the encirclement would overwhelm them.

The rebels felt the killing intent bearing down on them.

They saw their faces reflected in the rippling pools of blood and imagined what was about to happen.

But they also thought of the only way out of this hopeless situation, surrounded on all sides.

The center of everything. Its beginning and its end.

The ruler who stood at the highest peak in all the vast world.

"The Emperor…"

The faint voice that slipped from someone's lips swelled into a shout born of the desperate will to live.

"Capture the Emperor!"

The victor was king; the loser, a rebel.

Already driven to the edge of a cliff, they had no other choice.

A body without a head could not move.

Capturing the Emperor and his family to make the rebellion succeed was the only way forward.

"Whoever captures the Emperor and his family will become a marquis and enjoy wealth and glory for generations to come!"

At that moment—

Rumble!

Thousands of men and horses surged forward like a wave.

Toward the Emperor looking down at them from the high steps, his face worn with age.

They tried to drown out their fear of the woman standing before him with furious shouts.

"GRAAAAAH!"

"Charge! Don't stop!"

Their cries, almost screams, mingled with countless footsteps and pounding hooves. The sound woke the deep night and spread through the thick darkness hanging on every side like a curtain.

Far away. Farther still.

Loud and clear.

Yet their desperate advance and shouts seemed unbearably slow and distant.

At least, they did to the young man and woman looking at each other in that moment.

He looked at her. She looked at him.

The hundred or so *jang*[3413] between them meant nothing now.

They both knew.

They knew they were looking at each other. They knew whose gaze had met theirs across the distance.

But only So Gyo had realized the other person's true identity.

So it was you.

Swallowing a cryptic murmur, So Gyo silently looked down at the battlefield spread out beneath her.

It was vast. And it was horrific.

The grand banquet hall, stretching for hundreds of *jang*[3414] in either direction, was awash with blood. Ownerless weapons and severed limbs lay scattered across the ground. The wide-open eyes of the dead held no trace of life.

The music that had sounded for a brief while was gone. Only death remained in its place, and more people were surging in to pile death upon death.

Whoosh.

[3413] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3414] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Amid the enemies' thunderous shouts, a cold wind billowed her silky hair. It carried the smell of blood deep into her nose, thick as the crimson pools all around her.

Thick enough to draw fragments of the past up from where time had buried them.

Thick enough to revive the horrific memories she'd wanted to forget but never could.

Perhaps that was why she felt not the slightest joy, though she had found the answer—the key—she had sought for so long.

Perhaps that was why she knew it was time to end this long and gruesome banquet.

Shhk.

In the silence, So Gyo moved both hands. The two curved swords gripped in her blood-caked hands pointed toward sky and earth. Then she brought them together.

Shrring. Clack.

Steel forged by a craftsman's countless rounds of quenching and hammering rang coldly. A hidden groove and the metal set within it joined the two weapons.

As if they had been one from the beginning.

As if they had once been something other than curved swords.

Wooooong.

Restored to its original form after long years, the weapon trembled in its owner's hands. It resonated with the familiar energy flowing deep into it and shed tears of light.

Zing.

The air quivered.

A pure-white flash joined the two angled ends that had made the pieces look like curved swords.

Just as it had in the distant past.

Still bearing the splendor of an age when it had been divine punishment to some, salvation to others.

"It's been a long time."

So Gyo lifted her beloved weapon, her voice tender.

Then, as she had done tens of thousands of times before, she gripped the flash joining its ends and pulled hard.

Fwoosh.

A brilliant shaft of light took shape in midair, nocked against the shining bowstring.

The unbelievable sight stirred the old memories of someone watching from afar. It raised someone's figure from a past buried in dust.

An old woman who had ruled the battlefield with a bow larger than any other, unleashing Force like lightning.

“The Bow Saint…!”

At that very moment—

SHWAAAAAK!

The shaft of light flew from So Gyo’s—or rather, the Bow Saint’s—fingertips and streaked across the grand banquet hall.

Chapter 921

Fwoosh!

The moment they saw the streak of light hurtling toward them, the three thousand rebels charging as one instinctively understood.

Unavoidable death awaited them on the only path they had thought could save them.

“Dodge—!”

KABOOOM!

Someone’s scream was swallowed by the deafening roar. Amid the dust cloud that billowed up with the explosion, headless corpses and men and horses torn limb from limb shot into the air, spraying fountains of blood.

“GRAAAH!”

“S-spread out! Spread out at once and keep charging!”

“Don’t stop! If you stop, you die!”

Urgent commands rang out over countless screams.

Overcome by fear and confusion, the rebels forced strength into their trembling legs at the orders of their surviving leaders.

That was right.

If they stopped here, it was all over.

They had climbed onto the back of a rampaging tiger. Their fate was already sealed.

“AAAAAAH!”

“Charge! Chaaaarge!”

Bloodshot eyes wide in faces white as paper, the surviving rebels screamed in desperation and pressed forward.

Praying that the Force arrows liable to come flying from anywhere at any moment would spare them, at least.

Using the unlucky men at the front as shields.

Please, please!

They charged on with that desperate plea running endlessly through their clenched teeth. Then a dazzling streak of light appeared before them and blocked their path.

No. It swept them away.

BOOM! CRUNCH!

The earth shook. Rising dust soaked up blood and turned red.

Yet the gaze watching that horrific scene—and the hand that kept drawing the bowstring—remained terrifyingly calm.

Four hundred paces.

Ziiing.

The great bow shuddered. Its string and arrow, shining with their owner's internal energy, unleashed speed and force no other archer could match.

Just as they did now.

Thrum. Fwoosh!

Another gale of light swept over the enemy, bringing the death—and the screams—that awaited them. Each arrow made of Force snuffed out dozens of lives like candles in the wind.

Three hundred paces.

Again.

Two hundred paces.

Again.

KABOOM! KABOOM!

The closer they came, the more corpses piled up. The men at the front had been replaced several times over, and those charging now howled like madmen.

Toward their only way out, which was also where they would die.

They pressed on as pawns on a vast game board until they met the dazzling light that would be the last thing they ever saw.

Crunch!

How many had died by the time they covered half the four hundred paces?

How many more would die crossing the two hundred that remained?

No one could answer the question that suddenly occurred to them.

Not those collapsing as they felt the life drain away. Not those forced to leave their fallen comrades behind and keep going.

Not even the leaders, who sent their men ahead while shouting for the charge.

"We're almost there! Whoever captures the Emperor will be made a marquis and—!"

Poom!

A sharp crack cut off the shout.

In the blink of an eye, the commander flew from his saddle and landed in a pool of blood.

Splash.

"Ugh!"

"G-General of the Swift Cavalry!"

No one heard the rest of what he said, but looking at the General of the Swift Cavalry lying motionless in the blood, no one could help thinking of death.

He was unmistakably dead.

The powerful commander who had held military authority for so many years had died just like that.

Suddenly, miserably, and leaving one question behind.

How?

The leaders nearby were bewildered. The streak of light, far too powerful to seem like an arrow, had been nowhere in sight a moment ago.

Then who…?

As they turned to look for the unseen attacker, a low voice reached their ears.

“There’s something this old man wants to know. What do you call the bastards who started this goddamn mess?”

Someone else answered.

“What else? They’re fucking assholes.”

“Then what about the ones hanging back even now?”

“Hmm. Shitheads?”

“And if they’re both?”

“In a four-character idiom? Fucking dog-shitheads.”

“Fucking dog-shitheads, is it? That rolls right off the tongue.”

Not in front. Not behind. Not to either side.

The leaders, frozen like statues, slowly looked up.

Two people stood in midair above their heads.

A dreadful thought came to them: perhaps the sight before them and those voices would be the last things they ever saw and heard.

“W-wait. If you help us now, we can give you whatever you want…”

Whoosh.

A breeze blew. That was all.

It should have been all.

Then why were their minds growing hazy? There had been two people standing above them. Where had one gone?

“You fucking…”

A voice squeezed out between someone’s lips.

Shhk.

Deep within their bodies, death woke late and stretched. Faint red lines appeared where a spearhead had passed too quickly to see.

Slip. Fwoooosh!

Blood welled in small beads, then burst out. Heads, arms, and legs separated; bone and flesh came apart and slid away, defying their owners’ will.

The collapsing bodies fell behind the young man holding a spear untouched by blood—and poured down over his head.

Thud-thud-thud!

The young man standing beneath that red rain in the dark was Jin Taekyung. He finally gave them his answer.

“Help you? The best help you bastards can offer is to just fucking die. You fucking dog-shitheads.”

“…!”

“…!”

Those who had witnessed the horrific, unbelievable sight before their eyes were struck with shock—and despair, as they realized it was all over.

Every one of them wore splendid clothes. They were powerful figures who had pledged loyalty to Dark Heaven and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, committing their families for generations to come. They had crossed a river they could never return from.

It’s over. Completely.

Jin Taekyung stood with his spearhead lowered and a calm expression, despite the hundreds of guards surrounding him. Jeok Cheongang still stood in the air.

Only then did the onlookers understand that their dreadful premonition had come true.

This vast rebellion was finished. So were the wealth and glory they had enjoyed for so long.

Their only consolation was that, instead of enduring brutal torture before being torn limb from limb by carts, they might receive a quick death from that martial-world ruffian.

Or so they thought.

Until Jeok Cheongang spoke.

“Leave the ones who look like the top dogs alive. I don’t know if they’re gold mines or spent ones, but we won’t know what’s in there unless we dig. Might as well take a few swings with the pickaxe.”

“…!”

“…!”

Their shock and resignation turned to fear in an instant. Before that instant was over, Jin Taekyung sent ten sharp cracks through the air toward them.

Fwish-fwish-fwish!

They weren’t given time to take out the poison pills they had kept hidden, just in case—or even a moment to draw the daggers at their waists and slash their own throats.

Thud-thud-thud!

They felt it.

Finger Qi crossing the distance in an instant and stiffening their entire bodies. The world slowly tilting as despair weighed down on their minds and bodies.

Slip. Thump!

They fell like waterlogged logs. Golden flags fluttering on every side filled their vision. Above the dragons writhing on the flags, countless arrowheads rained down across the dark sky.

Shhhhhhh.

A thousand repeating crossbowmen poured steel over the remaining rebels.

Thud-thud-thud!

The sounds of flesh being pierced announced the end of the blood-soaked banquet. Screams of pain joined them, mingling with the powerful, unceasing beat of drums.

Thick and sticky as blood.

Boom. Boom. Booooom.

Fifteen minutes.

That was how long it took for all three thousand rebels to be wiped out.

The Imperial Army swept into the grand banquet hall beneath a rain of arrows, bringing more than enough force to put an end to the long, horrific feast.

“Rebels, listen!”

“Rebels, listen!”

“Disarm and surrender at once!”

“Disarm and surrender at once!”

Shouts charged with powerful internal energy rang out one after another.

The twin officers urging them to surrender sounded so alike in voice and tone that they could have been one man. At the sight of them, the surviving rebels seemed to lose their last hope.

Clunk. Clunk.

Clang.

They loosened the joints of their bloodstained armor and dropped their cracked and broken weapons as if throwing them away.

No one knew who surrendered first, but the wave soon became a tide sweeping through the grand banquet hall.

“I surrender. I’ll surrender.”

“Please, just spare my life…”

Their eyes were vacant, their faces empty.

Some clutched the stump of a missing arm and begged for their lives. Others, backed to a cliff's edge with nowhere left to retreat, made a choice they could never take back.

Stab.

"Kh… Urgh!"

A body pitched forward with a muffled death rattle.

The nameless rebel crumpled. His face held the despair of knowing it was over, and a trace of the peace he had found in escaping this hell.

"It's over."

At the faint words Jeok Cheongang murmured as if to himself, I forced myself to nod calmly.

Yeah. It was over.

The vast battle that had swallowed countless lives, both in plain sight and out of it, had finally ended.

But not everything was over.

The dead had gone somewhere far away, never to return. But the monster who was neither dead nor alive still remained here.

And we still had to deal with the living.

Squish.

A footstep landed in a pool of blood.

I watched her approach, my gaze cold and steady. Each light, graceful step left a sticky imprint of blood behind.

So Gyo.

No—the Bow Saint.

The woman who had kept everything about herself hidden.

At our first meeting, she had pretended to be the Emperor's loyal servant. At our second, she had worn the mask of Dark Heaven. Only at our third had she finally revealed herself.

Now she was coming toward me.

With catlike steps that suited the name So Gyo, she crossed ground strewn with countless bodies. People who might still be alive if she had revealed her identity a little sooner.

Fwoooosh.

Blade-sharp qi rose from every part of my body. The Bow Saint stopped a few steps away and looked at me in silence, then suddenly spoke.

"So it was you."

What did she mean?

I hesitated, unable to understand the meaning behind her words. A low voice sounded in my ear.

—The one the Martial God spoke of. The chosen one.

…What?

Chapter 922

What made humans seem so special in a world teeming with life was their ability to think deeply and broadly.

Every human could do it.

They took in their current situation through their eyes and ears, thought about what to do or say to the person in front of them, and put together the right words.

At the same time, they predicted what those words and actions would bring about.

But their predictions weren't always right.

When things took an unexpected turn, or the person they were talking to reacted in a way they hadn't anticipated, they were thrown off.

Their racing thoughts came to a halt. They lost their words.

Just like me, right now.

"So it was you."

So Gyo—no, the Bow Saint—stared at me. Her lips moved, and a voice only I could hear slipped between them.

—The one the Martial God spoke of. The chosen one.

…What?

The shock of learning that So Gyo was the giant known as the Bow Saint had completely disappeared.

That brief Sound Transmission hit me like a sledgehammer to the back of the head. I could only blink.

I'd expected an excuse, at least.

With me making no effort to hide my anger, I thought she'd say she hadn't expected things to turn out this way. That she'd had no choice.

But she didn't.

The Martial God.

And the chosen one.

I stood frozen like a statue, unable to make sense of those words or what they meant. Then the Bow Saint's Sound Transmission continued.

—Yes, you must be confused. I was, too, a long time ago.

A long time ago? Just when was she talking about?

What had the Martial God, who had vanished into the distant past, told her?

But the question that flashed through my mind was cut short before it could even take shape.

—It's a long story I've kept to myself. But talking here and now wouldn't be wise.

I desperately wanted to press her for answers, but the Bow Saint's Sound Transmission was enough to remind me of the situation I'd momentarily forgotten.

Right.

The bloodbath that had unfolded here today was over, but not everything was finished.

The curtain had fallen, but the curtain call remained.

The actors on this blood-soaked stage still had parts to play.

I'll get my answers after that.

I nodded. The Bow Saint understood and quietly turned away, flicking a glance at the one person who'd stood beside us all along, watching in silence.

"That old hag hasn't changed. No, she looks younger, but the look in her eyes is even more unpleasant."

Jeok Cheongang muttered under his breath, then added, "Playing games through Sound Transmission with some young punk right in front of this old man, too."

"…"

"What? You think I wouldn't notice?"

I peeled a crust of dried blood off my cheek. "I figured you would. And even if you hadn't, I would've told you myself."

"You sure know how to talk."

"So, did you hear everything?"

"Do you think the title Bow Saint belongs to Gaettong next door?"

"Then I'll tell you. Every last word. I won't leave out a single syllable."

Jeok Cheongang studied me for a moment, then clicked his tongue.

"Forget it. There's no rush, and she must have had her reasons. Anyway…"

Pat. Pat.

His solid palm tapped my shoulder. He turned his head sharply away, speaking in a gruff voice.

"Uh, well. What I'm trying to say is… hmm."

"Yes?"

"No, what this old man means to say is… Hey, look at you. Are you laughing?"

A laugh must have slipped out without my realizing it.

But I didn't rush to wipe the smile from my face like I used to.

I knew how he felt. And he'd understand how I felt, too.

Thank you. For coming back to me.

That was what Jeok Cheongang had said just a little while ago, when I'd been hovering between life and death, after I finally clawed my way back from death and recovered.

Now it was my turn to say it to him.

“Thank you. For always being by my side.”

I murmured it barely loud enough to hear, then looked up at the empty air as if something there had caught my attention.

It was a little embarrassing, and I wasn’t sure I could face his reaction.

But… well. Sometimes you want to say these things.

Even when you know each other so well that long explanations aren’t needed, sometimes you just want to tell someone how you feel.

And for all his immense martial prowess, Jeok Cheongang was remarkably bad at that.

“Ahem. What’s a hairy bastard like you doing saying something so revolting…”

He hesitated behind another unnecessary cough, then let out a quiet laugh. In the direction he pointed, a group was hurrying toward us.

“This old man’s a given. Save your thanks for them. They threw themselves into a deathtrap just to save you. They deserve at least that much praise, don’t they?”

I turned. Familiar faces were rushing toward me, drenched in blood from head to toe.

One, two, three… six.

They’d all survived. Not one of them was missing.

That was enough. More than enough.

Ah.

Was it the overwhelming relief? Or the exhaustion I’d forgotten?

All the strength went out of me at once. I staggered and began to fall.

No—I nearly fell.

Hands reached out from every side and caught me before I could.

Grab.

Jeok Cheongang, Hyuk Mujin, Ju Hwaran, Song Ilseom, Sama Pyo, Taishan, and the Divine Physician caught my arms and legs. They held me up as I started to topple.

They weren’t a burden to bear. They were pillars holding me steady.

Each of them had returned to this deathtrap hoping to help, even a little. Each had become my greatest reason to win this horrific battle.

“Damn it. I should be lending a hand at a moment like this, but this guy’s so tall I can’t reach him.”

At the mournful complaint from the old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent perched on Taishan’s shoulder, everyone let out a quiet laugh.

Even me, though I’d been about to close my eyes and give in to the sleep demon.

No. Not yet.

I clenched my teeth and forced strength back into my failing body. Then I left their worried looks behind and started walking.

To bring this hellish night to an end.

To finish off the monster who had created a hellscape no painter could ever depict.

Step. Step.

I walked, and kept walking.

Past the dead and the rebels, bound tight in thick iron chains and struggling to break free.

Past dozens of flags rising high above me.

Until, at last, I saw the monster writhing alone at the Bow Saint's feet. Across that vast space, there were no more cries of protest or screams.

"Eastern Heaven Demon Lord."

At my call, the monster stopped moving.

The moment Jin Taekyung's low voice reached his ears, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord felt all the strength leave his body.

Why?

He didn't know.

Maybe it was because the man before him was Jin Taekyung—the one who had stood in his way at every turning point, every moment when the course of events might have changed.

Or maybe he'd been waiting for someone other than the Bow Saint, who had watched in silence all this time, to stop him.

To stop this meaningless struggle.

This hollow sense of defeat and fury, now that he could no longer achieve his goal.

"Yes, it's you."

A volcano cooled soon after spewing its lava. Now the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had cooled, too.

"You're late. It's rude to keep someone waiting this long."

Jin Taekyung looked down at him in silence, then spoke.

"Well, I don't think that applies to a monster like you who can't even die."

"A monster, is it? So that's how you see me?"

"Yeah. And to be precise, I'm not exactly polite to people, either."

"Ah. So you were born rude."

"If you'd said that in front of my mom, she would've beaten you to death."

"Didn't you just say I couldn't die?"

"Mom's Divine Palm hits your soul. Not your body."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord let out a hearty laugh before he could stop himself.

“I think I know what you mean. You have a point.”

Once, he’d had a mother, too.

She was gentle most of the time, but when he did something wrong, she’d scold him harshly and smack him on the back.

Even after all these years, he could faintly remember how it had hurt.

“Yes, I remember. I had times like that, too. My Master was usually gentle, but sometimes he’d take out the switch.”

Yet the more he recalled those happy memories, the more the smile on his lips faded.

“But… now I can’t remember.”

Once, those days had been the present.

They had been today, and yesterday.

But now, the only faces left in his memory were twisted hideously with pain. All he could see was them dead or dying.

“You bastards! Heaven will punish you!”

“Go! Hurry!”

It made no sense.

His mother’s piercing scream as the soldiers brutalized her while she fought to protect her only surviving child, and his Master’s final words—those memories were so vivid. So why were their smiling faces so faint?

Why were they blurred as if lost in fog?

Crack.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord clenched his teeth so hard that his molars shattered.

But the pain that should have followed never came.

Only the result remained: they were broken.

Just as the people around him had died screaming.

Just as he had chosen to become a monster instead of a human being.

“Do you know something?”

His lips, wet with blood, moved. His eyes, fixed on Jin Taekyung, the Bow Saint, and the countless people who had gathered around him, flickered with cold flames.

“This is only the beginning.”

He spat out each syllable, filling it with anger.

He swallowed his resentment toward the world and his grief at knowing he could never be happy again.

“Even if you’ve protected the Imperial Capital, you can’t stop the fires spreading throughout the land.”

He had spent more than half a century in the imperial court. No one had gone without sheltering for a time beneath his vast shadow, and no one had escaped Dark Heaven's reach.

Those frogs had left the great well of the Imperial Capital, each taking up an official post somewhere in the land. There they had put down new roots, grown branches, and borne fruit.

That was why the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord could smile.

He thought of the Great Nation soon to be engulfed by civil war and a raging fire. He thought of Dark Heaven's forces advancing into the Central Plains with those flames before them.

"On that day, the Great Nation will fall."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord threw his head back and laughed, looking at the Emperor standing before him and mocking the helplessness he would feel.

Chapter 923

How many people feel no fear in the face of death?

Very few.

No—none.

Of course, if you turned the whole world upside down and shook it out, you might find a few. But even among Murim warriors, whose guts are in a league of their own compared to ordinary people, I'd swear there wasn't a madman like that.

After all, it's only natural to fear death when you've lived a life of your own.

A battle-hardened veteran who's survived countless brushes with death and a green kid who hasn't even lost the down on his face are equals before it. Both are afraid.

All the more so if death comes with a full course of unspeakably horrific torture first.

But there are exceptions to everything.

Like the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, laughing at the top of his lungs before the Emperor.

"Ha! Hahahahaha!"

Sprawled on the ground without his limbs, he was a wretched sight.

Yet his laughter rang out like a victor's.

The final death he'd put off once—perhaps dozens of times—was at last upon him. Still, I couldn't find a trace of fear in him.

Was it simply because his body couldn't feel pain?

No.

Even if he'd been an ordinary human instead of a monster, he would have laughed just the same.

He would have cursed the imperial family and the Great Nation that had taken everything from him, and gladly accepted torture and death.

After all those years, the only thing the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had left was his grievance.

Self-reproach and regret that he hadn't completed his revenge with his own hands.

That was all.

The only truth, the only outcome. Nothing more, nothing less.

"It's over. Completely."

Jeok Cheongang's mutter was clear enough.

No sweet words or kind gestures would get information out of the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord now.

Like a horse galloping across a wilderness without looking back, his path had been set long ago.

"I've seen eyes like that before. Don't waste time. Kill him now, before he can cause any more trouble."

He wasn't speaking only to me. Jeok Cheongang was speaking to everyone here.

It was the greatest respect he could show the people who had fought beside him on the same battlefield—and a proposal addressed to one man.

The ruler of this vast continent.

The Emperor.

"Your Majesty."

Jeong Hogun, a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, stepped forward with a sword broken in half. Blood covered him from head to toe.

"Please, give your command."

But the Emperor didn't answer.

He stood with his lips pressed shut, gazing down at the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, exhaustion on his face. Some time passed before he spoke.

"What do you think?"

At first, I didn't know who he was asking.

But as the Emperor's gaze settled squarely on me, and the people around us erupted as if a dam had burst, I understood.

The Emperor was asking *me*, of all people, what should be done with the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

"Y-Your Majesty!"

"You mustn't!"

"How could Your Majesty, the sovereign of all under Heaven, ask a mere subject—not even a minister of the court, but a lawless ruffian from the martial world—"

"Lawless ruffians from the martial world, you say."

The Emperor repeated the words quietly and looked around. Officials in court robes had gathered on every side of him.

He studied their faces one by one. Many had survived because he and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had been focused solely on each other.

"How strange," the Emperor said at last. "The ruffian you speak of fought so hard he's covered in blood. Yet you ministers of the court have come through this fierce battle looking remarkably untouched."

"…"

"…"

Silence fell in an instant.

Having shut everyone up with a few words, the Emperor turned back to me.

"Now answer me. I want to hear what you think."

I didn’t know.

I didn’t know why he’d singled me out, or what answer he wanted.

But I didn’t dwell on it. As always, I could just say what I had to say.

“If I opposed killing him, would you let him live?”

A single, explosive question that no one had expected. I heard people around us catch their breath.

Even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stopped laughing and opened his eyes wide.

The Emperor’s gaze didn’t waver.

No.

“Why not?”

I wasn’t asking because I didn’t know.

Everyone here needed to hear the answer, even if the people beyond the palace walls never did.

I trusted the Emperor to understand what I was doing.

“He is a traitor without equal in history. For years, he kept My Father blind and deaf to what was happening. He used poison to slowly drive most of the imperial family to their deaths, including My Eldest Brother, the Crown Prince.”

Shock rippled through the crowd.

Everyone held their breath as the Emperor revealed a history that had remained hidden. Until now, the world had believed that he himself was the root of all the evil.

“By the time I learned the truth, it was too late. Traitors bent on destroying the Great Nation had seized control of the imperial family and held most of the real power.”

Everyone here could imagine what had followed.

An Emperor reduced to a puppet. Princes already poisoned.

Those heirs to a noble bloodline had neither time nor people left to turn to.

Except for one old general who had protected the Embroidered Uniform Guard with unwavering loyalty, and the Great Nation’s fourth prince, who was far from the throne and had been wandering the provinces.

“There was only one way left.”

And so a restoration took place under the guise of a rebellion.

More than a decade ago, right here in this grand banquet hall.

In a single night, several hundred high-ranking court officials died. Before long, tens of thousands more were exiled or executed.

The fourth prince wielded the blade of the purge without hesitation.

He climbed the bodies of the traitors who had tried to destroy the Great Nation, with the unseen glares and curses of its people at his back.

All the while, he promised himself he would soon reveal the truth and wash away his disgrace.

“Then the late Emperor and the other members of the imperial family were confined because…”

“I tried everything to cure them, but even the Imperial Physicians couldn’t determine what was wrong. They spoke of a great physician who wandered the world like a cloud and could drive away even the Grim Reaper. If we found him, they said, there might be a way.”

“The Divine Physician.”

“Yes.” The Emperor’s expression turned bitter. “But in the end, I could never find him.”

I’d heard the story from the Slaughter Saint himself.

He and the Divine Physician had wandered the land treating its people. Those who remembered their kindness had hidden them from the imperial family’s search.

If the imperial court had found them then…

History would have changed.

Even if the poison that cast its long shadow of death over the imperial family had been the Blood Soul Gu, the Slaughter Saint and the Divine Physician I knew might have found some way to deal with it.

Instead, that twist of fate ended with the deaths of the late Emperor, the crown princes, and several other members of the imperial family. The fourth prince, once so far from the throne, became a usurper and an unfilial son in the eyes of the world.

“Why didn’t you tell anyone? Why keep the truth hidden?”

“It wasn’t that I wouldn’t. I couldn’t. At some point, anything I said or did sounded like a usurper making excuses. It was only when My Father regained his senses at the very end and told Me he would pass the throne to Me that I understood.”

It was a stain he could never erase.

Though the fourth prince had formally received the throne and become the ruler of all under Heaven, people turned their backs on a truth they couldn’t believe.

To them, he was a usurper blinded by ambition, a son who had dragged his father from the throne.

As if that weren’t enough, a murderer and parricide who had led countless families and members of the imperial clan to their deaths.

The traitors who had brought the Great Nation to the brink of ruin became loyal patriots. Those who had tried to protect it were left covered in filth.

And yet…

He had no choice but to go on. He had to pull out the enormous weed that had spread its shadow across the Great Nation, roots and all.

“I took the Imperial Capital and purged countless traitors, but the main stem survived. That restoration was only half a success.”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord hadn’t been the monster he was now.

He’d fought the Bow Saint and Baek Yeon, suffering injuries so severe he could never recover. Then he’d proposed a deal.

His life in exchange for the fate of the Great Nation.

“For Me… it was an offer I couldn’t refuse.”

The Emperor was the realm, and the Imperial Capital its center.

But the Emperor and the capital were not the whole realm.

If the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had been killed that day, the Great Nation would have split in two and plunged into a massive war.

With the country hanging by a thread, the only path the fourth prince could choose would have given those who had conspired with the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord long ago, and had waited for the right moment, another excuse to rebel.

“I had to prevent that. No more blood could be spilled.”

The fourth prince had taken up a sword as soon as he could walk.

By the time the calluses on his hands felt natural and the reins were familiar to his touch, he was marching off to war.

Time and again, he’d led armies with outstanding martial skill and strategy, earning great victories. But whenever he went to the battlefield, he would murmur to himself:

This will be the last war.

It has to be the last.

The throne? Glory as a general?

He needed neither. He’d let go of any desire for them long ago.

His brilliant, kind eldest brother would make a sage king. The fourth prince had fought in dozens of wars, great and small, for one reason alone: he wanted the realm his brother would rule to be at peace.

That was all.

But. But…

“So this is what it came to.”

Shing.

The fourth prince—the Emperor—drew his sword.

He looked at me over its shimmering blade, still spotless despite the countless dead it had cut down.

“Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I ask you again. Do I need another reason to kill him?”

“What you’ve told us is enough,” I said.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord wasn't the only one who had waited for his chance at revenge.

"Then that settles it."

The Emperor's voice was calm, though something fierce burned beneath it. He brought his sword down.

Toward his family's enemy.

Against the traitor of all time, who had plunged his country and its people into misery.

Or he would have.

The Emperor's treasured sword was moving with enough force to split the man in two when a clear young voice rang out.

"One thing is still missing."

Whoosh!

The blade hissed through the air.

The Emperor stopped it a hair's breadth from the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's throat. He turned. So did I, and everyone else.

We saw a boy in clothes spotted with blood, his eyes calm and sad.

Prince Shangshan. Zhu Bao.

Everyone was looking at the young prince. He looked only at one person, and his small, still-growing feet carried him toward that man.

"Your Highness! Your Highness!"

Hong Jin, nowhere to be seen until now, called out in alarm. He must have gone to his master's side as soon as the battle began.

Prince Shangshan didn't stop.

Step.

One step.

Step.

Another.

No one could stand in his way.

At that moment, the boy they saw was a man.

Not a young prince, but another ruler.

And that man, that ruler, slowly bowed his head.

To someone who could not let go of his anger even before death.

Toward the enemy who had killed his parents and siblings.

Swish.

The hem of Prince Shangshan's robe brushed a pool of blood. He bent deeply toward the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord and spoke.

“I’m sorry. I know no words can comfort you, but… I sincerely apologize for what my grandfather did.”

“…!”

“…!”

Everyone was speechless.

The Emperor, the Bow Saint, the Fire King, and me.

Even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

“Ah.”

A quiet groan slipped between his parted lips.

He looked at Prince Shangshan with trembling eyes, then smiled faintly.

“What a damnable thing.”

Thrust!

The blade resting against his skin sank into his throat.

Chapter 924

Thuk.

There was no resistance. Nothing to stop it.

The imperial family's treasured sword cut through the flesh and bone against its edge like tofu, doing its job regardless of its master's wishes.

"…!"

"…!"

Silence fell.

No one there had expected this.

Who could have imagined that a vengeful ghost who had devoted his entire life to bringing down the accursed imperial court and the Great Nation would choose this path?

That he would thrust his own neck onto the blade held out by his enemy's descendant?

And yet, fate, once twisted, would not grant him death so easily.

Grrk. Cough.

Blood and phlegm bubbled through the gaping wound in his throat. Gasping for breath, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord felt his body slowly, little by little, beginning to recover. A rasping laugh escaped him.

What a farce.

He had made himself a monster to survive. Now he was struggling to die.

The power he had once considered a blessing had become a curse that held him captive.

What kind of farce is this?

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord stared up at the sky and laughed emptily.

He resented this body that would not die, however much he wanted it to.

He did not want to meet the inscrutable eyes of Jin Taekyung and the Emperor as they looked down at him.

And…

He could not bring himself to face the child still bowing deeply to him. The boy was barely more than a baby.

No. He was ashamed to face him.

"Twelve years. It was twelve years ago."

Cough.

He spat out the bloody froth rising in his throat and slowly went on.

"I watched from a distance as a child, still young enough to be nursing, left the imperial palace in a eunuch's arms."

The eunuch was Hong Jin. The child was Zhu Bao.

“I wanted to kill him. More than once, even after that.”

But he had not done it.

It was not only because Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao would make the perfect puppet to depose the Emperor and take his place one day.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had dimly suspected that the Emperor’s decision to make his youngest brother Prince Shangshan and send him far away was a ruse. Even so, he could never bring himself to order the assassination.

He hadn’t even known why he agonized over it so much.

No. He had known and pretended otherwise.

“That child… reminded me of myself.”

In the little boy who had lost his parents and siblings, in that small child being carried out of the palace as if in flight, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had seen his own past.

Messenger pigeons arrived at regular intervals with news of the boy. In those few written lines, he could read his loneliness.

“They said that far away, more than ten thousand li[3415] from here, the five-year-old cried every night. His sobs were so loud they could be heard over the walls.”

For better or worse, the child was precocious. At five, he had learned the truth.

He was far more special than other children, and perhaps just as much more unfortunate.

Other children did not call their mothers their wet nurses.

“Time passed quickly. By seven, they said, he no longer cried. He’d grown lively instead, practicing martial arts day and night.”

But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord knew better.

In those few lines of the missive, he could still see the child crying.

“He had only learned to hold back his tears. Just as I once did.”

Something he didn’t want to get used to.

Something he had no choice but to grow used to.

So the child held back his tears. Night after night, he hid from the eunuch and wet nurse who cared for him so devotedly, buried his face in his blanket, and cried without a sound.

If they heard him, they would be sad.

If his sobs carried beyond the walls, he would lose his dignity as a ruler.

Seven years old.

The child had grown up and faced reality.

Far sooner than anyone would have wished.

[3415] In this Chinese setting, one li is 500 m (0.311 mi). Ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,110 mi).

“That was when I finally understood. I could no longer kill him.”

Time flowed on like a river.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, unable to recover from the injuries he had suffered at the hands of the Bow Saint, performed his sect’s forbidden ritual and turned himself into a jiangshi. Meanwhile, the child, whose days had always been much the same, met a young man.

Jin Taekyung.

The Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

A wastrel who had only just taken his first step toward turning his life around.

And that third young master of an unremarkable martial family gave the boy something his life had never held before.

A dream.

“‘Dreams come true.‘ That was what it said.”

When the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord read those words in the missive, he laughed despite himself.

The nerve of that young punk, spouting such nonsense to a prince—even if he was only a child. Funnier still was the boy turning that nonsense into a plaque and hanging it in his residence.

But it left a bitter taste, too.

He had once had a clear, shining dream of his own.

And as long as he lived, the child’s dream could never come true.

“Even then, I found myself wondering what dream he held deep in his heart. What he hoped to achieve.”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord slowly turned his head.

The boy was still bowed low, trembling faintly. At some point, his eyes had filled with tears, and he could not bring himself to straighten up and show them.

“Now I want to hear his answer. He must be thirteen by now.”

Twelve years had passed.

The child had become a boy. The old man had become a monster.

And now, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao struggled to steady himself.

“My dream…”

He slowly straightened his back and gave voice to the dream he had kept in his heart.

“Is to make certain no one else suffers the misfortune you and I endured.”

“…!”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes trembled.

So did everyone else’s.

“That… will be impossible.”

"That is why it is a dream."

"Do you mean to wish for it, knowing you cannot achieve it?"

"It is a dream because I will not give up. Because I will keep trying, with all my might, to make it come true."

"Do you know what it is you're speaking of?"

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord could no longer hide how shaken he was. Prince Shangshan answered quietly.

"An age of peace and prosperity."

Four characters that had been the wish of all the people since ancient times, and had always betrayed them.

Yet here was a boy of thirteen speaking them aloud.

He was saying that he, at least, would not betray the people. That he would usher in another age like the reigns of Yao and Shun,[3416] when all had lived in peace and happiness.

Every word was sincere.

"I will punish the wicked and reward the good, regardless of their station."

Uprightness.

"I will always watch over and cherish the people, and heed the counsel of those around me."

Humanity and righteousness.

"I will respect every one of my people. I will look beyond their birth and accept their good hearts and wisdom."

Propriety and wisdom.

"And I will sow no seeds of misfortune. Whatever consequences come of that, I will bear them and take responsibility for them."

"Ah."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord groaned.

The meaning behind the young prince's final words—*forbearance*—cut into his heart like a blade.

"I… I could forgive nothing. At some point, I began to curse everything."

At the end of a brutal age of turmoil, the warlords who had caused him to lose his family had turned to dust and disappeared.

Taizu, who had burned his sect and slaughtered his Master and fellow disciples, was dead as well.

But the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord remained. So did his thirst for revenge.

No, it burned more fiercely than ever.

Against those who were left. Against people who had done nothing wrong.

[3416] Yao and Shun are legendary ancient Chinese rulers whose reigns are traditionally held up as examples of virtuous government.

“But how… how can you…!”

Unable to bring himself to look straight at the boy, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord closed his eyes and cried out, his voice boiling over.

It was not the anger he had felt before.

He was simply more anguished than ever.

Even now, he could not let go of everything.

And he was ashamed.

The boy before him was holding out, in his small hands, the forgiveness the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had failed to find in a lifetime.

“Do you know something?”

At the sudden question, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord opened his eyes.

Prince Shangshan was looking at him, his gaze trembling.

“When I learned the whole truth today, I wanted to kill you more than anyone.”

“Then why…?”

“Because my heart ached for you. I realized what made us different: the good fortune I was given, and you were not.”

Prince Shangshan slowly turned his head. A man stood beside him, looking haggard but entirely at ease, as if there were nowhere else he could be. The young prince’s gaze fell on him.

“I had a subject closer to me than family.”

His name was Hong Jin. He had been at the prince’s side from his earliest memories until this very moment.

“And I had an elder brother and loyal subjects who endured countless humiliations for this country.”

The Emperor closed his eyes with a low groan.

The loyal old general and the Embroidered Uniform Guards, who had been forced to seize the throne to confront a greater injustice, clenched their teeth, trying to suppress their agitation.

“When I could not see even a glimmer of light, there were people who reached out to me without asking for anything in return.”

The martial artists of Murim.

People who had stepped outside the Great Nation’s laws and built a world apart.

Yet they had willingly torn down that boundary and rushed into a place where danger waited on every side.

Prince Shangshan’s gaze passed from one to the next. One awkwardly scratched his bald head. Another gave him a gentle nod. One was rubbing his stomach as if he were hungry.

And at the end of his gaze stood a young man.

He was neither the strongest nor the wisest among them. Even so, he stood at the center of them all as naturally as if he belonged there.

He had planted a dream in someone's heart and promised to be his friend. Now he smiled at the boy who had grown so much.

His smile was so bright and warm that, for an instant, even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord thought the world before his eyes had grown brighter.

Chivalry.

He had forgotten that single word for so long it felt strange to him. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord turned it over in his empty heart.

Then he saw himself reflected in the young prince's tear-filled eyes: warped and blurred, like a monster.

"The man I saw in you was not only a sinner of the ages, burdened with unforgivable karma. You were also an unfortunate person who had no choice but to walk a different path from mine."

Unfortunate, he had chosen revenge instead of forgiveness.

Inhuman, he had become a monster.

He had thought revenge was the only path. It was the reason he had lived on, first as a human being and then as a monster.

But he had been wrong.

About his purpose. About his reason.

"Now… you can stop."

The quiet words reached him, and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord went rigid.

You can stop now.

It's all right to stop.

Those simple words melted a heart that had spent so many years burning to ash and freezing over, again and again.

At last, they brought him peace.

So that was it.

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord looked silently up at the sky.

He had resented it without end.

The sky. The whole world.

But when the last veil of anger fell away from his heart, he saw a new world.

Countless stars shone in the sky that had seemed filled with nothing but darkness. A breeze from somewhere carried the scent of grass.

It mingled with the thick stench of blood rising from the hellscape he had made.

Too late. I realized far too late.

Thousands upon thousands of people had already been killed or wounded.

And how many more would be sacrificed because of his choices?

He couldn’t even begin to guess.

Nor could he measure the weight of the crime he would bear for the countless lives swallowed up in the great war he had set in motion.

Yet here, at the end, a new fork in the road lay before him. It whispered insistently that he should make the better choice, even if only by a little.

As if that choice could make his whole black-stained life pale beside it.

—Listen carefully to what I’m about to say.

Whoosh.

The Sound Transmission slipped between his moving lips and mingled with the wind.

It passed the young prince and the Emperor, crossed the ring of Embroidered Uniform Guards and the assembled civil and military officials, and reached one man.

Jin Taekyung.

“…!”

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord smiled bitterly at the sight of Jin staring down at him, eyes wide.

It was far too late. But at the very end, he had made a slightly better choice.

That was all.

—I’ve told you my story. Now it’s time to collect my fortune-telling fee.

Jin Taekyung watched the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord in silence, his gaze sunk deep. Then he nodded and stepped forward.

Splash.

Ripples spread across a pool of thick, sticky blood.

Everyone watching knew what Jin Taekyung was about to do. Not one of the civil or military officials tried to stop him.

They did not dare.

The Emperor and Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao had stepped aside themselves to clear his path.

At this moment, Jin Taekyung was the Emperor’s appointed proxy, granted the authority to execute this great traitor on the Son of Heaven’s behalf.

Shing.

A cool breeze brushed the spearhead he held in a reverse grip. As the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord watched blue-white flames gather slowly at its tip, he spoke.

“Do you think someone like me will have a next life?”

“Probably. You’ll have to spend about three thousand jiazi[3417] as a cockroach or a mosquito first, though.”

[3417] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional Chinese calendar. Three thousand jiazi is 180,000 years.

I see. I suppose so.

At Jin Taekyung's matter-of-fact answer, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord let out a dry laugh. Jin Taekyung continued in an even voice.

"But in your next life, make sure you're born human again."

"What do you mean…?"

"You never know. Maybe someone will help you then, unlike in this life."

"…!"

"If we get the chance, let's meet again. Just don't be too late."

The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord—no, Wei Zhong—fell silent. Then he smiled faintly.

Without another word, he watched the dazzling flames fill his vision.

Whoosh.

Their warmth, strange as it was, wrapped around his entire body.

Chapter 925

Flames surged upward.

They burned with a fierce, terrible heat—and yet, somehow, they felt strangely warm.

Fwoosh.

The blue-white flames that had pierced his body along with the spearhead burned everything, melted everything, and, at the same time, embraced it all.

A man's unhappy life.

A monster who had realized his mistake only at the very end.

Goodbye, Wei Zhong.

I murmured the name I'd seen on the pledge the day before.

And at that moment, the chains of immortality shattered—the imperfect blessing and curse that had bound him.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

As I listened to the clear chimes announcing the arrival of eternal rest, I drew back the Scorching Yang Qi I'd been pouring through White Flame's spearhead.

Less than a handful of ash remained on the blackened ground.

Whoosh.

Was it a chance gust of wind, or a kindness from someone above who had watched it all?

I watched the ash drift far, far away.

Then a man's voice broke the brief silence.

"He was a traitor who tried to bring down the imperial family for his own ends, and a criminal who colluded with foreign enemies to plunge the Great Nation into ruin."

Without taking my eyes off the ash, I asked, "Do you think that was too peaceful an end for a man like that?"

"I do."

"I think so, too."

No matter how much he'd reflected and repented, the crimes he'd committed would not disappear. Everything he had done as the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, not Wei Zhong, was a burden he would have to carry even in Hell.

"Then why did you do it?"

"Why didn't you stop me, Your Majesty?"

The Emperor answered.

"Because I didn't want to."

A short answer, but it said everything. I let out a dry laugh.

"I see."

"Now it's your turn to answer."

"I…"

I paused and bit my lip.

"…Some people came to mind, that's all."

"People like Wei Zhong, then. Sinners who committed wrongs they could never wash away."

"Yes. And like him, they regretted the choices they'd made."

The Head Elder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been one of them. So had Baeksang of the Nanman Beast Palace.

They'd followed the guiding light of Dark Heaven down the wrong path and could never retrace their steps.

Sometimes they looked back and regretted the road they'd taken. But they'd gone too far to turn around.

Even as I poured my anger out on them, I couldn't help feeling sorry for them.

They could have made a better choice.

If they had, innocent people wouldn't have had to die.

But it was always too late.

That wasn't self-reproach or regret. What was done was done.

I could condemn the consequences of their choices. But I couldn't presume to condemn the choices themselves.

Revenge is easy. Forgiveness is hard.

That's what people are like.

"I will erect memorials."

The Emperor spoke again into the silence.

"One for those who fell here today. Another for the people sacrificed in the vicious struggles among the heroes of the realm. And the last…"

He paused, turning his gaze west, toward the place where the wind had gone.

"The Maoshan Sect. Yes, the Maoshan Sect would be fitting."

Gasp.

The officials around us sucked in their breath.

Erecting a memorial at the Maoshan Sect would tarnish the reputation of Taizu, the founder of the Great Nation, and the imperial family itself.

But before any of them could speak up, an even greater shock swept over them.

No—it struck them.

"And all of this shall be done in the name of the Crown Prince, not Mine."

"…!"

"…!"

The air seemed to tremble. Everyone’s eyes flew wide.

The Crown Prince.

The new ruler who would one day inherit this vast continent.

I’d completely forgotten why this gathering had been arranged. What awaited us at the end of this blood-soaked banquet.

The seat of Crown Prince had stood vacant for more than a decade. Now, at this very moment, it was about to welcome its new occupant.

“Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao, receive the imperial command!”

The Emperor no longer looked exhausted.

His voice, filled with the majesty only the sovereign of a nation could possess, pierced the air. Riding the wind, it enveloped the entire grand banquet hall.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Beginning with Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, thousands of guards drew their swords and pointed them at the sky.

Their golden armor flashed, as did their blood-soaked blades.

That brilliant tide of steel shone for one boy alone.

For the young prince who had chosen forgiveness over revenge even before his enemy. For the boy who dreamed of an age of peace no ruler in the past thousand years had achieved.

“Ah. Ah…”

The Emperor calmly addressed his younger brother, who stood at a loss before this sudden turn of events.

“Do you intend to defy the imperial command?”

“Y-Your Majesty.”

“Come closer.”

“But, but Your Majesty already…”

No one failed to understand what Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao meant to say, or where he was looking.

A woman stood surrounded by palace attendants, clutching her swollen belly.

I knew her name. She had gone from the favored concubine of the City Lord of Sichuan Province to a consort of the Emperor.

Aehyang.

She watched us through clenched teeth, anger plain in her eyes.

But the Emperor’s expression held not a trace of emotion as he looked at her.

It was as though she were a tool he had kept at his side because he needed it.

Wait. Could it be?

The thought had barely crossed my mind when the Emperor spoke.

“That child, when it comes into this world, will bear the blood of the late City Lord of Sichuan Province.”

“…!”

“Therefore, neither that woman nor the child in her womb has anything to do with Me. No one is to raise questions about this.”

The court officials looked stunned by his declaration. But a few of us, myself included, were certain of one thing.

The Emperor hadn’t spoken a single lie.

I suspected it, but it’s actually true.

The Emperor had an Empress and consorts, yet had produced no heir in more than ten years.

Looking back, though, it wasn’t that he couldn’t have an heir. He had chosen not to.

For the sake of his one and only younger brother, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao.

He must have wanted to protect him from every threat. The throne—and his younger brother.

The sole direct heir of the orthodox imperial lineage.

And, at the same time, a perfect puppet for Dark Heaven—a figure who gave them every justification they needed to overthrow the Emperor.

On the surface, it had seemed that the Emperor couldn’t bear to kill his little brother and had sent him into exile instead. But Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao had survived this long because of the Emperor’s plan.

“Do you still not understand?”

He had given up having an heir for his brother’s sake. For that same brother, he had had to become a coldhearted older brother. He went on slowly.

“I kept that seat empty for you from the beginning. Only you could take it.”

Though he had ascended the most exalted throne under Heaven, he had been branded a traitor and an unfilial son.

Though he tended to affairs of state day and night, that brand had made people call him a tyrant.

“I wanted you to survive. I didn’t want you to become My one weakness.”

Perhaps, when the child who had not yet been weaned was sent away from the imperial palace, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord hadn’t been the only one watching him go from afar.

“I had to send you away to protect you. And to root out the traitors I couldn’t eradicate before, I had to bring you back into this deadly place.”

More than a decade was no short stretch of time.

It had been long enough for the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord to shore up his weakened foundations. Long enough for the Emperor to prepare the decisive battle that would end everything.

And the Emperor had secretly brought his only younger brother back with the help of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, then protected him by keeping him confined.

He had even made an invincible master known as the Bow Saint serve as a mere bodyguard.

"Bao'er."[3418]

The voice that passed between the Emperor's dry lips was astonishingly warm.

Warm enough to make even Baek Yeon, who had stood beside him longer than anyone as comrade and subject, widen his eyes.

Warm enough to make the body and heart of a boy who had longed for his family for so long suddenly go rigid.

"It's time."

"…!"

At those quiet words, the boy's clear, river-bright eyes trembled.

But there was no hesitation in them. Only resolve, and the will of someone moving toward his dream.

"I, Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao…"

Swish.

The long hem of his robe brushed a pool of blood. Yet even on a battlefield stained red in every direction, the young prince's light had not dimmed in the slightest.

"…humbly accept the command of His Majesty the Emperor."

A smile unlike any anyone had ever seen spread across the Emperor's wrinkled lips.

"Granted."

"Waaaaah!"

Amid the earth-shaking roar, the two who had finally found each other after such a long, wandering road embraced.

Not as ruler and subject, but as brothers.

When the Emperor and the Great Nation's new Crown Prince embraced, those watching trembled, unable to contain the emotion rising within them.

"Ah…"

[3418] In Chinese, *-er* is an affectionate suffix added to a name.

How desperately they had wished, for more than a decade, that it had all been a lie.

That the natural order, twisted and blackened like a monster, would one day be set right.

And yet.

And yet, it had.

What they had yearned for in silence was unfolding before their eyes.

They had witnessed the end of one era and the beginning of another. Emotions they could not name surged through them, then spilled out in a tremendous roar.

“Long live His Majesty the Emperor!”

“May His Highness the Crown Prince live a thousand years!”

“Please, please put this servant to death!”

Cheers and cries rang out on every side.

Some who had known the truth laughed and wept like children. Others, deceived by lies into condemning the Emperor, staggered with guilt and regret.

But some belonged to neither group.

“Long live! Long live! Long, long live!”

Dry lips called endlessly for the Emperor’s long life. Tears drenched wrinkled cheeks.

Yet the shrewd gray eyes taking in the scene remained dark and still.

I never thought things would go this wrong.

The old man swallowed the words he must never let escape his lips and considered the chance that remained to him.

But it isn’t over yet.

He had known the truth from the beginning and joined hands with the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord solely for wealth and glory. He had no intention of being exposed as a traitor and seeing his entire clan slaughtered.

The pledge. I only need to get rid of the few people who know about the pledge and who I really am.

The saying “Succeed and you’re a king; fail and you’re a traitor” was wrong.

Even if you actually plotted treason, it wasn’t a crime as long as you weren’t caught.

The old man had once tutored the former Crown Prince. Revered by Confucian scholars throughout the realm, he had risen to the rank of Grand Academician. And in matters like this, he was meticulous.

I’ll survive. Just as I always have.

Repeating that resolve to himself, the old man cried out “Long live!” amid the confusion of the crowd, inching backward.

He needed to reach the subordinates waiting outside the imperial palace as quickly as possible.

If he eliminated the handful of key figures who knew his identity and took possession of the pledge, he could keep his current position. And even if things became difficult, he could take his family's wealth and flee.

Or so he believed.

Until someone's voice, strangely clear amid the deafening roar, pierced his ears.

"Where are you off to in such a hurry? A time like this calls for sharing the joy."

"…!"

The old man went rigid.

He slowly turned his head and saw a young man approaching at an unhurried pace.

"Jin… Taekyung."

"Come on. Just 'Jin Taekyung'? That's cold."

Jin Taekyung gave him a small smile and added, "You should call me Comrade Jin Taekyung."

"What, what are you…"

"You didn't know? I signed the pledge, too."

"…!"

"Oh. Have I got the wrong person?"

Jin Taekyung tilted his head. At that moment, a cold voice sounded behind the old man.

"It's been a while, Grand Academician."

Thwack!

A blow struck the back of his neck. As his vision went black, one name came to mind.

Hong Jin.

It was over. All of it.

Chapter 926

Everyone makes the wrong choice sometimes.

At least a few times in life.

No—count the little choices we make every day, and the number might run into the thousands.

But a wrong choice doesn't mean your life is over.

You can regret it, learn from it, and choose a better path next time.

Of course, that only works if you get a *next time*.

"I—I've done nothing wrong! This is a misunderstanding!"

"Your Majesty! Your Majesty!"

"You scoundrels! How dare you lay hands on me!"

Fear. Desperation. Anger.

Dozens of people shouted, each caught up in their own emotions.

Their silk robes had lost none of their sheen, and their plump bodies spoke to just how high their station had been—even in a place death had just torn through. But all the wealth and glory they had enjoyed until now were over, effective this very moment.

Such was the fate of those guilty of high treason.

"Arrest every last one of them!"

"Loyalty!"

Swish, swish!

No sooner had Baek Yeon given the order than the Embroidered Uniform Guards surrounding the area swung their binding ropes and scabbards into action.

One civil official, already resigned to his fate, let himself be bound without a word. An old general in dazzling armor resisted, showing off a fair amount of skill in martial arts.

Then he got his skull cracked.

Whack!

"You bastards, how dare you—Guh!"

"Let's not wear ourselves out already. Come quietly. You'll have plenty of chances to scream later."

"W-what are you going to do with me?"

"You already know, don't you, old Assistant Military Commissioner?"

"…!"

At the Embroidered Uniform Guard's cold smile, the old general sank to the ground, his face blank.

He had realized that the warm blood running from the crown of his head was nothing compared to what he would be made to shed later.

And one man was weaving his way through the chaos.

“It’s been a while. Last time we met, I think you called me a ball-less eunuch bastard.”

One man.

“You haven’t forgotten me, have you? Oh, we’ve never met? Cut the crap. I remember everything.”

Two men.

“Oh, look who it is. You’ve gotten so fat I almost didn’t recognize you. Don’t worry. I’ll slim you down this time.”

“…”

Every line out of his mouth sounded like a death threat.

Each time Hong Jin greeted someone as warmly as a man at his first school reunion in ten years, gold-armored diet supplements marched over and dragged that person away.

Their faces were flushed at the tantalizing prospect of a fresh batch of prisoners to fill the Embroidered Uniform Guard’s jails, which had stood empty for some time.

“W-wait! Torturer Hong!”

“I’m not a torturer anymore. It’s been ages since I was appointed Deputy Military Commissioner of Shanxi Province. Stop making a racket calling for me and go on ahead. Oh, and give your balls a good wash.”

The man who had once committed defamation by stating a fact[3419]—calling Hong Jin a ball-less eunuch—was dragged away. Watching him go, the second man—the one who had claimed they had never met—swallowed hard.

“Um, Comrade Hong. I think there’s been some misunderstanding…”

“Who’s your comrade?”

“Pardon?”

“Do you know me? And what misunderstanding? Drag this traitorous bastard to the jail and throw him in.”

Watching everything unfold at lightning speed right before my eyes, I murmured to myself.

There’s going to be a bloodbath.

I couldn’t even guess how many would die. Hundreds? Thousands?

Or tens of thousands, like last time?

And once the traitors who weren’t here today and their families were counted, the purge would be massive.

“Do you pity them?”

[3419] Under South Korean law, stating a true fact can still constitute criminal defamation.

At the Emperor's sudden question, I gave a small shake of my head.

"Those bastards committed crimes worthy of death. Of course they should pay for it. It's just…"

"You're worried that people with nothing to do with the treason will be sacrificed."

"…"

"It cannot be helped. The law of the land must be upheld, especially where treason is concerned."

"I know. I understand."

Revenge begets revenge.

If someone survived the purge with a grudge and plotted for the future, they could become the seed of another disaster.

Just as the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had.

"But there may be exceptions."

My eyes widened at the unexpected declaration.

"You mean…"

"Make every cause and connection crystal clear, and spare at least those who are innocent. That was what Bao'er[3420] asked of Me just now."

The Emperor added with a faint smile, "It was also his first request of Me as Imperial Younger Brother and as My brother."

"…!"

"That boy will become a sage king who brings about an age of peace. He will care for his people more than anyone, and they will love him in return."

Had this man always smiled so much?

The Emperor, whose face had always been cold and gloomy, looked much brighter now.

His eyes rested on Prince Shangshan—or rather, Zhu Bao, now the Imperial Younger Brother—as the boy met his gaze and awkwardly bowed his head. The warmth in the Emperor's eyes was impossible to hide.

Even the Emperor is still just an older brother, in the end.

I gave a quiet snort and said, "That's right. He'll definitely be a sage king."

"He is also highly skilled in martial arts. One day he will cross the Great Wall and conquer the vast grasslands, the lost lands of the Northern Sea, and the deserts as well."

"Huh?"

"What is it?"

"Um. Nothing. It's possible."

I wanted to ask what martial arts had to do with any of that, but I held back.

[3420] The suffix *-er* is an affectionate diminutive in Chinese names.

Why was I starting to think of Jin Wikyung?

“Indeed. Entirely possible.”

“Of course.”

“And that is not all. He will build cities of gold and establish a great empire that will endure for a thousand years.”

“…A thousand years is a bit…”

“Do you think that’s impossible right now?”

No, even if I thought about it as hard as I could, that seemed a bit much.

But the Emperor’s eyes narrowed. I swallowed the words on the tip of my tongue and showed off my dazzling reflexes.

“I just thought you were aiming a little low. I was thinking ten thousand years.”

“Ten thousand years is impossible.”

“…”

“Perhaps it’s because you’re a Murim practitioner, but you do have a rather fanciful streak. You should try to develop a more realistic outlook.”

This son of a bitch.

I’d tried to play along, and he’d gone all serious on me. I was left speechless. Just then, a hand discreetly poked me in the side.

Poke.

I didn’t need to turn to know who it was.

I tamped down my anger at the Emperor and moved my lips.

—Don’t worry. Even if I am a Madman, do you really think I’d beat up the Emperor?

Jeok Cheongang replied through Sound Transmission.

—You’re certainly capable of it, but that’s not what I meant.

—If that’s not it, then… don’t tell me—

I turned, eyes wide, and Jeok Cheongang nodded gravely.

—You’re going to hit him yourself, Old Master?

—…

—Good heavens, have you gone senile again? You can’t. If you lay a hand on the Emperor, it’s over for all of us. If he gets pissed off at us and cozies up to Dark Heaven, we won’t have a Great Nation anymore. We’ll have a Dark Heaven Nation. With Hell thrown in.

I was still desperately trying to talk him out of it, like a missionary at Yeongdeungpo Station shouting that believers go to Heaven and unbelievers go to Hell, when Jeok Cheongang gave me a withering look and jerked his chin over my shoulder.

—Before I pluck those dog eyes out, look who’s waiting behind you.

I turned. In the distance stood someone watching us with calm, still eyes.

The Bow Saint.

The instant our gazes met, the relief and joy that had surrounded me seemed to wash away.

An inexplicable chill seeped deep into my lungs.

—So it was you.

The question I had yet to answer—and that voice—lingered faintly in my ears like a breeze at dawn.

—The chosen one the Martial God spoke of.

What had she meant? What truth lay behind those words?

My gaze wavered despite myself.

The Bow Saint gave me a slight nod, then quietly turned and began walking.

Toward somewhere out of sight of the crowd.

Toward a secluded place where she could reveal the secret she had kept until now.

I followed the Bow Saint without a word.

As if to prove that the battle in the grand banquet hall had not been the whole of it, bodies and blood that no one had yet cleared away lay throughout the once-clean, spacious imperial palace.

Still, no one stopped me and the Bow Saint as we crossed the palace at an unhurried pace.

If anything, people hesitated, then bowed and stepped aside.

They recognized us.

They knew who we were, and which side we had fought on—the Emperor's or the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's.

But unlike them, I still didn't know.

I didn't know what the Bow Saint's cryptic words meant, or much of anything about the figure shrouded almost entirely in mystery.

The Martial God.

A peerless hero born of the Great Faction War, who had appeared out of nowhere one day and vanished just as suddenly.

No—he had become the very sky looking down upon all of Murim.

People said there had never been anyone like the Martial God, and there never would be again.

There were mighty figures known as the Three Saints and the Ten Kings, but the Martial God stood in a realm none of them could reach.

That was why they called him the sky. A god.

But…the Martial God was gone now.

The symbol and center of Murim had vanished like a phantom just after disbanding the Murim Alliance.

As though he had never existed.

As though he'd been waiting for this to happen from the beginning.

As the years passed after his sudden disappearance, rumors sprang up like weeds.

Some said he had died after failing to recover from the internal injury he sustained in his final life-and-death duel with the Heavenly Demon. Others said he was spending the rest of his life in some remote mountain valley.

And that wasn't all.

Some claimed that, having attained enlightenment, he had finally become an immortal.

There were plenty of wilder rumors, too: that the Martial God had always been something like a divine beast protecting the Central Plains, and would never appear in human form again.

With so many mysteries surrounding him, the Martial God had always been a fascinating subject.

The tales of his deeds sounded like myths and legends.

Even to those who had seen him up close. And to me.

And yet…

For that Martial God to come up so suddenly.

I hadn't seen so much as the Martial God's little finger, but the mere mention of his title made every hair on my body stand on end.

Now that we had reached our destination and stopped, the feeling was stronger than ever.

Rustle.

The deep night was giving way to dawn.

Even the sound of wet grass brushing against us had a chill to it. The Bow Saint slowly looked around, then spoke without turning.

"You've been here before, haven't you?"

She looked like a young woman barely into her thirties, but the Bow Saint was an old master who had lived through ages beyond my imagining.

I answered with the respect she was due.

"Yes."

"I remember you charging at me as though you meant to kill me. It left quite an impression."

The Bow Saint reached out and lightly tapped a flower bud that had yet to bloom.

Countless rare and beautiful plants filled this place. It was the same abandoned space where she and I had met a few days ago.

“Whenever I felt troubled, I would come here for a walk. People treated it as forbidden ground, so there wasn’t so much as an ant around.”

“Then that day, too…”

“That’s right. Something was troubling me. No matter how much I thought about it, I couldn’t reach a conclusion, so I came here to walk and think.”

The Bow Saint turned. Her eyes curved like crescents, but the gaze within them was grave and still.

“You were the chosen one the Martial God spoke of, someone who was supposed to possess the supernatural powers to escape even death…so why are you in an irrecoverable state?”

“…!”

Chapter 927

An inexplicable shiver ran down my spine.

A supernatural power that could even evade death.

I knew better than anyone what it was. There was no other way to describe it than as something uncanny, like the work of ghosts.

The System.

A stroke of luck that had come into my life when it was sinking like a boat with a hole in its hull.

A power that had brought me both my greatest crisis and my greatest opportunity.

Yet in this world called Murim, only one person besides me knew the System existed.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

No one else could know the true nature of the power I possessed.

Not the Bow Saint, and not even the handful of people who had stayed closest to me.

They might have some vague sense that there's something there, but that's as far as it goes.

I'd crossed the line between life and death more times than I could count.

I'd survived situations that would have killed an ordinary person several times over, and I'd grown at a pace without precedent in Murim's history.

Even so, no one knew exactly what my power was.

No—not unless I told them the truth myself.

That was the kind of power the System was.

An ability beyond anything a human could imagine, one that even the four characters meaning *supernatural powers* couldn't fully capture.

Even the Bow Saint is no exception.

The shock I'd felt a moment ago had already settled. But one question remained, and I couldn't answer it on my own: how had *they* learned there was something special about me when only a handful of people knew?

The Bow Saint. And…

The Martial God.

The shadows of two giants who had vanished from the world long ago fell over me now.

Not like shade that offered relief from the heat, but like darkness.

It made my skin crawl.

I licked my dry lips. My mouth felt as rough as if I'd chewed and swallowed a fistful of sand.

What on earth do they know? How much?

Just as I sent the unspoken question drifting through my mind, the Bow Saint—who had been watching me in silence with deeply shadowed eyes—suddenly spoke.

“You’re calmer than I expected. I thought you’d ramble on with excuses. Or pretend you didn’t know.”

I forced myself to answer evenly. “Would that change anything?”

“No. Nothing at all. You know that, too, don’t you?”

That answer made one thing certain.

The woman before me—the Bow Saint—had been watching me all along.

And she knew more than I’d imagined.

Then could it be…? No. That can’t be.

I pushed away the question that had flashed through my mind and asked sharply, “Since when?”

“That short question seems to hold several meanings. Let’s see… I’m not sure how to answer it. Why don’t I start with what happened today?”

The Bow Saint gently brushed the flowers lining either side of the path as she continued.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. When I saw you rise even though you should have died, I finally knew who the chosen one the Martial God spoke of was.”

“How could that man—no, how could he…”

“How does he know about you?”

I nodded, keeping my agitation in check.

Every nerve in my body felt drawn taut.

Depending on her answer, everything could change. What happened next could take a turn even I couldn’t predict.

Then the Bow Saint gave a short reply that stopped my thoughts cold.

“How would I know?”

“What does that—”

“Neither I nor he could have known. Of course not. I found the letter before you were even born.”

“…A letter? Before I was born?”

“Yes. I first found it after many years had passed since the Great Faction War ended—long enough for the mountains and rivers to change more than once.”

Her calm voice mingled with the dawn air and drifted to my ears.

“At first, I thought it was simply a trace left by some unknown person from long ago. But I was wrong. The Martial God had left that letter for me.”

“Then what exactly did it say?”

“An arrangement he had made. No—perhaps a kind of prophecy.”

“…!”

“And there was one term that appeared throughout it.”

My chest felt tight, as though a great stone had settled inside it. I forced the words out.

“The chosen one.”

“That’s right. And ‘the chosen one’ didn’t necessarily refer to any one particular person.”

Step. Step.

Her careful footsteps carried her past the blades of grass. Faint moonlight fell over her as she walked through the garden.

“I couldn’t believe it, but I had no choice.”

Because he was the Martial God.

Awe she couldn’t conceal filled those words. Her voice as faint as the moonlight, the Bow Saint continued at the pace of her steps.

“So, after several decades, I went out into the world and traveled the land. I spent most of my time in the Central Plains, but once I went as far as the endless desert in the west. Another time, I crossed the grasslands and reached the Northern Sea, where moss and ice covered everything.”

Searching for the “chosen one” mentioned in the Martial God’s letter was like searching a field of sand for one special grain. The Bow Saint had to shoulder the entire burden alone.

“I couldn’t ask anyone for help. The letter said not a single detail about the mission could be revealed until I’d succeeded.”

But the Bow Saint hadn’t given up.

The Martial God’s arrangement, almost a prophecy, required someone called the chosen one.

“When the whole world is covered in darkness, that person will become a lamp and light the way. The only one who will open a new sky and bring the morning.”

The Bow Saint murmured the words, then turned her face toward the sky.

“But no matter how long I searched for someone whose age, face, name, and even gender I didn’t know, the chosen one never appeared.”

Of course not.

Finding one person in this vast land—someone who might not even have been born yet—was nearly impossible.

“But not entirely. If what he wrote in the letter was true, the chosen one would stand out with astonishing speed.”

A needle in a bag.

Sooner or later, the needle was bound to poke through. No matter where it was, or how deeply it was buried in a crowd.

“I followed rumors and sought out people I thought might be the chosen one. But even at Heaven’s Gate Temple, where the brightest talents in the land gather, I found no reason to be certain.”

Heaven’s Gate Temple was where Jin Mukyung, my second older brother and the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, had spent some time.

It was a cradle of talent, crowded with the heirs of prominent sects and gifted people of every kind.

But even its cadets, remarkable as each of them was, fell far short of what the Bow Saint expected of the chosen one.

“They were all outstanding, but that was all. Every one of them had a clear limit. As did I.”

I’d listened in silence until then. At last, I understood why she, like the other Three Saints, had disappeared from public view—though her disappearance had been overshadowed by the Martial God’s.

And why she had been staying in the Imperial Palace.

“You used the imperial information network.”

“‘Cooperating with’ would be more accurate than ‘using.‘ That was before the current Emperor, then the Fourth Prince, staged his coup.”

“Then does the Emperor know…?”

“No. He suspects something, vaguely, but he knows nothing. That was one of my conditions. What matters is that after he took the throne, I gained access to information from every corner of the land.”

The Bow Saint was a weight on the scales, powerful enough to tip the balance in an instant.

Disguised as a palace attendant, she stayed by the Emperor’s side and learned what was happening across the land, from the smallest incident to the largest. The presence of an unidentified Supreme Peak master also restrained the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s movements.

“In many ways, it was the right choice. Staying in the Imperial Palace let me learn things I’d never seen or heard before.”

One was Dark Heaven, which had sunk its roots deep into the imperial court. The other was…

“Someone who was growing beyond my sight.”

The Bow Saint looked away from the sky and toward me. Our eyes met, and I quietly swallowed.

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan. Jin Taekyung. At first, the names were unfamiliar, and I had no interest in them. Not until the second piece of news came from Shanxi.”

“What second report?”

“The unbelievable story that the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, had taken on a Disciple.”

The Bow Saint smiled faintly.

“Of course, the reports that came in quite some time after that were far more surprising.”

A year after the Jin Family of Taiyuan took control of Shanxi Province, I finished my secluded training on Mount Jiuhua and descended the mountain.

I was nothing like the person I’d been before.

In my martial prowess. In my state of mind.

And there were major events waiting for me, too.

“Each time I heard news of you, I grew more interested. No—it was more than interest.”

The chosen one.

The lamp that would light the night. The one who would open a new sky and bring the morning.

The unknown person the Bow Saint had searched for so long was slowly emerging from behind the curtain.

“That was why I had to see for myself. I needed to know which of the two people I was weighing in my mind was the chosen one.”

Two people.

The word cut through my ears with unusual clarity. A name flashed through my mind like lightning.

“…Cheongpung.”

At the name that escaped me, the Bow Saint gave a small nod.

“Yes. Cheongpung, the Huashan Divine Dragon. He had every chance of being the chosen one, too. If I hadn’t seen you in the grand banquet hall, I would have believed the Sword Saint’s Disciple was the one.”

But from her point of view, there had been no need to bring both of us here.

She was already fairly certain one of us was the chosen one.

And I had enough ties to draw me into what had happened.

“I already knew of your connection with Prince Shangshan—no, the Imperial Younger Brother. When Dark Heaven reached out to Hong Jin first, pretending to be on our side, I thought it might work in our favor. But I needed something more definite.”

Then I remembered.

Ma Sanbao had been the one who first contacted Hong Jin.

And saving Zhu Bao wasn’t the only reason I’d thrown myself into the death trap of the Imperial Palace.

“Blood Soul Gu…”

Was this what it felt like to be struck in the back of the head with a sledgehammer?

I spoke through a groan.

“Were you the one who planted the Blood Soul Gu in the City Lord of Sichuan Province?”

The Bow Saint’s bitter smile burned itself into my eyes.

Chapter 928

Blood Soul Gu.

A cursed venomous creature created by the Five Poisons Sect, which had once drenched Nanman in blood.

When I realized what had driven the City Lord of Sichuan Province to his death, everyone—including me—had been certain it was Dark Heaven's doing, and that it had deep ties to the Emperor.

But now I wasn't so sure.

What was true, and what was false? How much of what I knew could I believe?

And was the woman standing before me, watching me with a bitter smile, really on our side?

And…

If the Bow Saint was the one who planted the Blood Soul Gu, then what kind of being is the Martial God behind her—the one who foresaw my appearance?

The Martial God was shrouded in mystery, and my questions about him seemed endless.

Grind.

I ground my teeth and glared at the Bow Saint.

"I asked you who planted the Blood Soul Gu in the City Lord of Sichuan Province."

The Bow Saint watched me in silence, then abruptly spoke.

"What would you do if I said it was me?"

"…!"

A jolt ran down my spine. I forced myself to keep my voice steady.

"You'd have to explain yourself. Well enough to convince all of us, including me."

"And if it still doesn't convince you?"

"Then…"

I swallowed. Almost by instinct, I lowered my stance a fraction, ready to strike at any moment.

There was no absolute good or evil in this world. But Dark Heaven—and the Lord of Heaven—came close enough to absolute evil.

If the Bow Saint had used the Blood Soul Gu, which was deeply connected to Dark Heaven, and it had close ties to Dark Heaven, there was only one thing I could do.

"I wouldn't keep speaking to you this politely."

At that moment, a fierce wind swirled around us.

Whoosh.

No. It wasn't swirling. The winds were colliding.

The waves of qi pressing against each other were about to surge when the Bow Saint's narrowed eyes curved like a full moon.

"Good. That's how it should be."

"What…?"

"You've exceeded my expectations. In every way."

It didn't take long to understand what her smile and those few words meant.

A test.

The thought flashed through my mind, and the tension gripping my whole body snapped loose.

Damn it.

The Bow Saint frowned in mock disapproval.

"Hm. Still wet behind the ears, and you talk to your elders like that?"

"If you were really an elder, you wouldn't mess with someone who's still wet behind the ears."

"I've spent decades looking for you. What's a little teasing after all that?"

The Bow Saint smiled faintly. As she looked at me, there was a hint of approval in her eyes.

"So you had nothing to do with the City Lord's death or the Blood Soul Gu after all?"

"I had something to do with it."

The Bow Saint tossed out the bombshell as if it were nothing. She stroked a flower and continued.

"I sent him back into danger, knowing full well he would die soon. I thought that if he died in Sichuan, someone close to you there would notice what had happened."

"You knew he was going to die?"

"The City Lord of Sichuan Province was already infected with the Blood Soul Gu while he was staying in the Imperial Capital. Naturally, it was Dark Heaven's doing—or, more precisely, the doing of the City Lord's favorite concubine."

"Wait. Aehyang?"

"Yes."

My eyes widened. The Bow Saint went on in the same even tone.

"Don't be surprised. If you need to control someone and that someone is a man, there's no surer method than using a beautiful woman."

"But how did you know she was working for Dark Heaven just from that?"

"I investigated her discreetly myself and found that she was highly skilled in Soul Bewitchment. I'd heard he was neglecting his duties because he was besotted with women. I was keeping an eye on him when I had him summoned to the Imperial Capital."

A memory from not so long ago came back to me: the first time I'd met the City Lord, before the incident that came to be known as the Sichuan Blood Tragedy. He'd been half naked even then.

So even back then…?

A chill ran down my spine.

Not because I'd failed to notice that Aehyang, a Dark Heaven agent, was right beside him. Because I couldn't begin to guess how far Dark Heaven's shadow—its dark hand—had reached.

"Then does that mean…?"

"Yes."

The Bow Saint nodded before I could finish.

"Dark Heaven has reached the roots of the Great Nation. It has worked its way into every corner, so thoroughly that we don't know where its reach ends."

"…!"

"The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's death didn't end this. There are likely still quite a few local officials with real power, great and small, working with Dark Heaven. Generals who command armies, too. And that would include some of the City Lords who govern the provinces."

I swallowed.

A province might sound like a simple administrative division, but the land and population within one were enormous.

Why else had dozens of warlords proclaimed themselves kings and fought for supremacy in the chaotic age of the past? Just to claim legitimacy by calling themselves kings?

Half right, half wrong.

If you conquered a region and absorbed all the strength of its land, you could build enough power to claim the title of king of an entire nation.

These days, the City Lords were officials who answered to a powerful central government. But if they set their minds on rebellion, they could do tremendous damage to the Great Nation.

He wasn't exaggerating. He wasn't lying.

Before the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had accepted everything and let go, he'd poured out a curse in his rage.

This is only the beginning. Even if you protected the Imperial Capital, the flames will sweep across the land.

But they hadn't been empty words spat out in anger. There was truth in them. A time bomb that might go off before long.

Damn it.

My head felt hot. My breath came ragged though I hadn't moved, and my heart pounded.

I could almost see flames flickering before my eyes, ready to swallow both the modern world and Murim. And behind them stood the shadow of a giant who had swept aside the curtain and appeared when no one expected him.

"Then what do we do now? What do we do from here?"

I asked the Bow Saint, struggling to catch my breath.

No. The question was really for the person who had left a letter long ago and, through it, guided her to this moment.

The Martial God.

Born a man, yet called a god. He had saved the world once and left behind a plan to save it again.

I was asking him.

I wanted another prophecy from his letter to the Bow Saint. One ray of light to show me the way down this pitch-black road.

"What am I—fuck—what am I supposed to do?!"

I was practically shouting. The Bow Saint's answer held no light at all.

"I don't know. Neither does he."

"…!"

All the strength went out of me. My vision blurred, and my head sank.

I'd been sure there was something more. Something more to it.

I thought he would be different, if anyone could. He was the one who had been certain that a person like me would appear someday.

I'd even found myself thinking something impossible.

What if the Martial God—the greatest of all time, with his dazzling achievements and divine authority—

Maybe…

I clenched my teeth and was about to follow that unbelievable thought to its conclusion when a quiet voice reached my lowered head.

"But there is one thing."

I slowly raised my head as if under a spell.

The Bow Saint was there, gazing at me with eyes sunk deep.

"He left a message for the chosen one."

"What…what message?"

"Divine strength."

Why did those two words make me freeze? An inexplicable chill crept down my spine.

The Bow Saint spoke calmly and quietly, but her voice rang in my ears like thunder.

“He said the chosen one must forge a path with the divine strength and Will only the chosen one can possess. Just as…”

Her voice trailed off. In that instant, the world slowed.

An invisible curtain seemed to fall over my eyes and ears. I could see only the Bow Saint—her lips moving slowly. I could hear only the words passing between them.

Just as you yourself did.

“…!”

Time began to move again.

I didn’t. I stared at her, frozen as if I were trapped in ice.

I…what did I just…

What had I heard?

My mind felt as though it had emptied completely. A few words floated there, bright against the blankness.

Just as you yourself did.

Just as *you*, the Martial God, did.

That could mean only one thing.

The Martial God had been a chosen one like me.

No. More precisely…

A System user.

Player.

The word rushed in to fill my empty mind, swelling until it felt ready to burst. A clear chime rang out.

Ding.

And at that moment—

Slip.

I felt the sky and ground slowly turn over as I fell into pitch-black darkness.

Everything happened at once.

Jin Taekyung’s trembling form crumpled like a puppet with its strings cut. The Bow Saint’s hand shot out and seized his collar. And finally, the cold dawn air that had drifted through the abandoned garden suddenly grew hot.

Grab. Fwoosh!

The Bow Saint steadied Jin Taekyung, then spoke to the uninvited guest who had suddenly appeared.

“How strange. I don’t remember inviting you, too.”

The guest answered in a low voice.

“I do call him my Disciple. How could I leave him alone with some nasty old hag and not worry?”

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

His voice was calm, but flames flickered in his eyes.

“Fine. Let’s hear what kind of nonsense you’ve been up to.”

The Bow Saint gave a short laugh and shook her head.

“All these years, and you haven’t changed. Still charging in without thinking.”

“Do I have to say it twice?”

“You were hiding like a rat and listening. You already know. That was all I said. The boy was simply exhausted beyond his limits.”

She looked down at the unconscious Taekyung. Dried blood marked his face in several places, and the strain of his fierce struggle still showed there.

They were traces of how brilliantly—and nobly—he had fought.

“Take him with you. Let him get a little more rest.”

Jeok Cheongang didn’t hesitate for long. He carried Jin Taekyung on his back as if he’d been waiting for the chance, then used his movement technique to hurry away. The Bow Saint watched him until he was gone.

Then, suddenly, she saw a flower bud slowly opening in the light.

It was the first light of dawn.

Chapter 929

That night was unusually dark and long.

For the soldiers on both sides, who clashed again and again with blazing torches and sharpened weapons.

For the people, who trembled in fear and waited for the sudden upheaval to end.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

“Gah!”

The fighting was not confined to the Imperial Palace. The chilling clash of blades and the screams covered the entire Imperial Capital for several shichen[3421]. Countless people who heard them remembered the fourth prince’s coup just over a decade earlier, which had overturned the Great Nation’s order and changed the course of its history.

Amid the chaos, some were gripped by more anger and fear than anyone else.

“Those bastards! I could chew them to death and it still wouldn’t be enough…!”

“I-it’s over. The Embroidered Uniform Guard must have discovered us!”

Dozens of people faced one another across a table inside an abandoned shrine thick with dust and cobwebs. Shadows from a dim oil lamp flickered over them. They were of different ages and dressed in all manner of clothes.

An old man listened to their cries, then spoke.

“Enough noise.”

His voice was low but firm. As if on cue, everyone fell silent and turned toward him.

His slight frame and deeply wrinkled skin showed his age. Yet his eyes were clear and shrewd, and though his clothes showed wear here and there, not a fold was out of place. His bearing, like his dress, spoke of the life he had led.

“Don’t let yourselves be swept up in this. The path before us was decided long ago.”

The old man lifted his lukewarm teacup, seemingly unconcerned by the trail of torches drawing closer beyond the window or the great roar that came with them.

“I don’t know what’s happening out there, but it may be for the best. Now that chaos has broken out, it’s time for us to act.”

The time had come.

At his brief words, some eyes lit up. Others trembled, unable to suppress their fear.

Restoration.

It was why they had gathered here today, and the cause they had taken up to save one person.

[3421] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

“Now…we must put everything back where it belongs.”

The old man’s eyes flashed with a strength hard to believe in a man of ninety, and a resolve firmer than anyone’s.

“Let us drive those cruel traitors—who have abandoned what is right and overturned the natural order—out of the Imperial Palace. Let us raise His Highness Prince Shangshan to the throne by the strength of the people.”

“…!”

“…!”

An unseen surge swept through the shrine like a wave.

They had come of their own resolve, yet amid their rising excitement and fear, they had briefly forgotten what their undertaking meant.

By the strength of the people. Raise a ruler of the people.

They looked at one another.

They differed in age, status, and gender. But now they were comrades in the same boat.

Each had lived a separate life. They had come together to steer the great ship that was the Great Nation onto the right course.

A few days earlier, the words of someone whose identity they did not know had lit a fuse hidden deep in their hearts.

“The azure heaven that once shone blue is fading, and dark clouds are rolling in.”

As the tune slipped from someone’s lips, a young Confucian scholar joined in as though entranced.

“The storm soon to come will swallow the world.”

“But, people, do not tremble. Do not be afraid.”

An old laborer, his skin darkened by the sun, muttered in a rough voice. In his hand was an axe with a keen, blue-steel edge. Once, he had led an army.

“For there is a mountain, the highest in all the world.”

“There is a stream that never runs dry.”

“Fruit ripens there, and animals run free.”

“And a home to keep out the storms, and a forest to provide firewood.”

It was no longer any one person’s voice.

Reciting the song that had spread through the Imperial Capital’s marketplaces over the past few days, they rose to their feet.

“It can shelter all the people, and still have room for more.”

Step. Creak.

The old shrine groaned as they filed out. The song continued, louder and stronger than before.

“So, people, do not tremble. Do not be afraid.”

The old man led the way, his white robes fluttering as he stepped onto the damp earth.

As he made his way along the rugged mountain path, shadows crouched in the darkness rose and followed him.

From dozens to hundreds.

From hundreds to thousands.

Before long, they had become an army. They carried sickles still caked with dirt, and spears, swords, and axes red with rust.

Step. Step.

They marched toward the faint dawn light in the east and the trail of torches creeping up the mountain like a living dragon.

The song on their lips became a fervent plea, then a mighty roar.

“Go to Mount Shangshan, go to Mount Shangshan.”

Thousands of pairs of solemn eyes shone in the dark.

“Though the raging storm swallow the Five Sacred Mountains of the Central Plains, it will never dare reach Mount Shangshan.”

Thud-thud-thud-thud.

The low mountain trembled. Those torches drawing closer by the moment were likely the punitive force sent by the Emperor, who had realized a restoration was underway.

But…

“The lord of Mount Shangshan has Heaven’s protection!”

They raised their voices higher.

Highborn and lowborn alike strained their throats, fighting to suppress the fear still welling up inside them.

Only a few days ago, on a day like any other, an unknown man in a bamboo hat had cast those words into their hearts. Now they shouted them with all their strength.

“He is descended from the dragon that commands rain and lightning, and fit to be a just and benevolent ruler!”

And just as their great shout shook the land around them—

Whoosh.

An unusually sharp gust cut through the gray dawn mist. A man appeared from within it and spoke.

“That’s quite a fine song.”

“…!”

“…!”

Everyone’s eyes widened.

Dried blood marked the golden armor he wore, but could not hide it. That armor meant only one thing.

“The Embroidered Uniform Guard…!”

At the words, forced out like a groan, trembling eyes turned to the torches rippling a few hundred *jang*[3422] below.

Suspicion became certainty.

The Emperor had sent the Embroidered Uniform Guard to put down their restoration.

And perhaps Prince Shangshan had already…

“You monsters! Aren’t you afraid of Heaven?”

Some of the restoration army, consumed by rage, were about to rush at the man who was clearly an Embroidered Uniform Guard when the old man, who had led them all despite his age, suddenly spoke.

“Whose blood is on your armor?”

They stopped. The man answered evenly.

“The blood of traitors who endangered the ancestral temples and the state.”

“Then who are the traitors you speak of?”

“On the smaller scale, Wei Zhong, the East Depot’s Seal-Holding Eunuch, and those in league with him. On the larger scale, the foreign enemy called Dark Heaven.”

“…Dark Heaven. Dark Heaven, is it?”

The old man murmured the name. He knew of the force that had recently been drenching the martial world in blood.

And the voice of the man in bloodstained golden armor was familiar, too.

“Was it you?”

But unlike the restoration army, who could make no sense of this strange exchange, the Embroidered Uniform Guard understood what the old man’s brief question meant.

“It was.”

“Then what you said and did in the marketplace that day…”

“It was all done at His Majesty’s command—the imperial decree.”

“Ah.”

The old man let out a sigh. Some in the restoration army recognized the man at last, and their eyes widened.

“Could it be…?”

“Y-yes. That was his voice.”

[3422] A *jang* is a traditional length of approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

They remembered it clearly: a voice that had carried over a crowd of hundreds, and a man in a bamboo hat who had dropped a great stone into their hearts before vanishing.

“My surname is Lee. I once served the late Emperor as Grand Preceptor. What is your name?”

The man, now wearing a golden helmet in place of his bamboo hat, answered with the respect due to an elder official. Decades ago, Lee had repeatedly urged the Emperor to keep eunuchs at a distance, only to be falsely accused and driven from office.

“Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard. I have come to deliver His Majesty the Emperor’s command.”

His voice, charged with internal energy, pierced the dawn air and reached every ear.

“I was unworthy and failed to bring about an age of peace. I was unfilial and lost the late Emperor and the elders of the imperial family. But I have never once been disloyal. Now, at last, I seek to set the natural order right. Take up the banner of Imperial Younger Brother Zhu Bao and, with those who follow you, eliminate the traitors.”

“…!”

“…!”

The air seemed to stop. Shock swept through the restoration army like a great wave.

Imperial Younger Brother Zhu Bao.

Everyone understood what it meant.

Jeong Hogun walked slowly toward them with a banner in his hand. Beside a dragon embroidered in gold thread was Zhu Bao’s name. The sight erased their last shred of doubt.

“Ah…”

Cries of wonder rose all around him. The old man swallowed and fought back the tears gathering in his wrinkled eyes.

Then he dropped to both knees and accepted the Imperial Younger Brother’s banner in trembling hands.

“I receive and obey His Majesty’s solemn command.”

As the light of dawn grew clearer in the far west, the roar of thousands who had joined the Embroidered Uniform Guard broke the early-morning stillness.

They roused the people who had been paralyzed with fear and the loyal men who had already given up hope. Then they fell upon the traitors still locked in bloody fighting throughout the Imperial Capital.

They became a wave of people numbering tens of thousands—no, hundreds of thousands.

“Waaah!”

“Long live His Highness Prince Shangshan!”

“Long live His Majesty the Emperor!”

Crack!

“Gah!”

“Retreat! Retreat!”

Dawn was stained with countless screams and blood.

When that unusually dark, long night ended and daylight came, there were no more battles. Only the shouts of those pursuing the rebels, who had lost the will to fight and scattered in every direction, and their overflowing joy remained.

One day. Two.

Then three days passed in the blink of an eye, and someone opened their eyes.

Chapter 930

Strange.

The unfamiliar ceiling that should have been waiting for me, just like always, somehow felt familiar.

What is this?

As my vision slowly sharpened, I looked around.

The space was far too large to call a mere bedroom. Thick pillars stood between the curtains surrounding it, while braziers placed here and there and night-shining pearls set into the ceiling like stars bathed the room in a soft glow.

Wait. Night-shining pearls?

Then I realized where the déjà vu was coming from—and why the place felt familiar.

This is…

That's right.

This was a vast pavilion built to serve as both living quarters and a place to handle state affairs—and a fortress filled with an ironclad guard.

Qianqing Palace.

No wonder it felt familiar.

Without the night-shining pearls, it might have taken me longer to figure it out. Only an emperor could plaster his ceiling with pearls big enough to fetch hundreds of silver nyang[3423] on Bok Choy Market as if they were glitter stickers.

But…why am I here?

The question surfaced in my strangely empty head.

Whoosh.

A faint breeze stirred the curtains around the bedroom. At the same moment, a man in black appeared like a ghost and bowed his head slightly.

"Have you awakened?"

His voice was muffled, almost a mumble.

I stared blankly at the unexpected intruder, then calmly assessed the situation.

The Emperor's quarters. The Emperor's blanket. The Emperor's bed. The Emperor's pillow.

My clothes were golden from head to toe, and when I lifted my pants for a peek, even my underwear was gleaming golden silk.

The full King-God-Emperor package.

[3423] A nyang was a traditional Korean monetary unit. *Silver nyang* denotes silver currency, not Korean won.

And on top of that, No Shadow—the Emperor's hidden guard, an assassin and Supreme Peak master—was speaking to me with such courtesy.

Then could this be…

Through clear-headed reasoning, I reached a conclusion. A shudder ran through me.

"Possession…!"

It had to be. There was no other explanation.

I'd gotten a good night's sleep, woken up, and my life had changed genres from fusion Murim to a possession story. Just as I was reeling from the shock, No Shadow spoke in his usual muffled voice.

"Are you all right?"

Would you be all right? nearly burst out of me, but figuring out what had happened came first.

"What time is it? No, how many days have passed since the grand banquet?"

"…?"

Apparently, that was a strange question from an emperor who'd just woken up. No Shadow stared at me before answering.

"Three days."

"Three days?"

"Yes."

"…Then how long was I asleep?"

"Three days as well."

I squeezed my eyes shut.

Three days. In just three days, everything had gone to shit.

To hell with being an emperor. I'd gone from a handsome guy in his early twenties with his whole life ahead of him to a middle-aged man who looked ancient, and everything I'd achieved had gone up in smoke.

System window…open.

I silently tried the command, just in case.

But it scattered into the void.

There was no clear chime, no translucent holographic window.

What the hell is going on? How did things get like this?

I couldn't breathe.

The levels I'd busted my ass to gain, my stats—I couldn't even access the System window now. I might never make it back to the real world.

Wait. Then what happened to the original me?

The thought suddenly struck me, and my eyes flew open. I shouted at No Shadow in a panicked voice.

"Then what happened to me…? No, what happened to Jin Taekyung!"

No Shadow blinked above his pitch-black mask.

"You mean Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"Yes, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung! The guy who's handsome, tall, and perfectly muscled, and I have no idea why women aren't all over him!"

His answer brought my thoughts to a halt.

"He has yet to awaken."

"What?"

"For reasons unknown, he has not regained consciousness. I regret to report that, according to the examination of the one called the Divine Physician, he is as good as dead."

"…!"

"As a result, His Highness the Imperial Younger Brother has refused food and drink for three days. He said there was something he must return to a friend with whom he shared a bond…"

No Shadow trailed off and carefully held something out. I accepted it in a daze.

Rough, cold metal.

Gleaming like obsidian, it was the divine artifact of the Sichuan Tang Clan—the one I'd given Zhu Bao in case the worst happened.

The Myriad-Poison Ring.

I could see the boy who'd promised to survive and return it to me before long.

But…

Damn it.

I didn't know how it had happened, but that shitty fate had twisted my life into knots once again.

Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan was gone.

And perhaps Jin Taekyung the Hunter's life in Korea had ended here too.

Crack.

At some point, I'd clenched my fist so hard my knuckles had gone white. Then I saw the wrinkles covering the back of my hand, and the strength left me.

Slide.

My fingers loosened. The Myriad-Poison Ring rolled over my rough skin and fell onto the bluestone floor.

Clang. Clang.

The cold sound echoed alone through the vast room.

With hope drained from my eyes, I watched the Myriad-Poison Ring spin rapidly.

Each time the black gem caught the light of the night-shining pearls and flashed, faces I would never see again crossed my mind.

My family, more precious to me than my life. Team Leader Choi and so many other comrades.

All the people I trusted, and who trusted me.

And someone else I'd only just learned had been born to the same fate.

The Martial God.

Another System user. Another Player.

Someone chosen by this cruel fate long before I was.

Where was he now?

Had he gone through the same thing?

Or had the System chosen me as a new Player because he really was dead?

I didn't know.

Not right now. Perhaps not ever.

I was no longer the chosen one or a Player. The System knew the truth, but it wouldn't answer my questions.

No. I wouldn't be able to hear its answer.

That was the kind of power the System was.

A power meant for one person alone.

And so…another Player will appear.

The hollow thought hovered on the tip of my tongue without becoming words.

With my eyes sunk deep, I kept watching the Myriad-Poison Ring spinning.

It was still turning and turning on the blue bluestone floor, without end.

"…?"

Wait.

Something was wrong.

"H-how long is that thing going to keep spinning?"

No Shadow answered my cautious question.

"This is why I hate people who catch on too fast."

What?

Quietly. Very quietly, I opened my eyes to slits as narrow as a flounder's.

An unfamiliar ceiling came into view. Unlike the one from a moment ago, it was moderately luxurious and moderately Murim-like.

Good. First check passed.

I lifted a hand, moving so little I made no sound.

The glittering golden sleeve made my heart sink.

Second check, pending.

I ignored the cold sweat beading on my forehead and carefully lifted my pants.

I didn't know which son of a bitch had put this on me and called it underwear, but sure enough, it was dazzlingly golden.

Third check. This is getting shitty.

Afraid to confirm what was real, I closed my barely open eyes again.

A bad sign. But it wasn't over yet.

In the awful silence, I slipped a hand inside my pants and felt over my underwear.

The familiar weight—the one I'd have recognized anywhere, and was so glad to feel I could have cried—made my whole body shudder.

"Ah, ah…"

An indescribable electric thrill coursed through my whole body.

I was alive.

I was still alive.

This wasn't that shitty dream from a moment ago. This was vivid reality, the present in which I was alive and breathing.

I was Jin Taekyung the Hunter and Jin Taekyung the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

Damn it. What a thing to be grateful for.

Just being alive as myself felt overwhelming. I wiped a few tears away with my sleeve.

Then I opened my eyes to face the world with more gratitude than ever.

Ah.

I met the eyes of several familiar people who'd been watching me without making a sound.

"…"

"…"

"…"

"…"

The suffocating silence seemed as though it would last forever. The Divine Physician broke it first, his voice grave.

"That is perfectly understandable."

Beside him, Jeok Cheongang avoided my gaze.

"Yes. It's the Scorching Yang Qi. He's done nothing wrong."

The Bow Saint nodded and murmured, "Truly the chosen one…"

I took a quiet, deep breath.

It felt as though the world had stopped.

No—more accurately, I wished it would stop.

But even after I shut my eyes tight, made a fervent wish, and opened them again, the dreadful reality was still waiting for me right there.

The Divine Physician. Jeok Cheongang. The Bow Saint.

Fine. I could understand them. They were old enough to have been through every kind of trouble and seen every kind of thing they'd rather not have seen.

But they weren't alone in the room.

The Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Fuck. The Fire Dragon Pavilion.

I was looking at them. They were looking at me.

More precisely, they were staring at me with their eyes wide, as though they couldn't believe what they were seeing—at the sight of my hand inside the front of my pants.

Ah.

I barely swallowed the sigh that was about to burst out.

Then, as calmly as I could, I spoke.

"I know. It looks like there's plenty of room for misunderstanding."

"I don't think it's really a misunderstanding, mm."

Song Ilseom cut himself off when he saw my expression.

Beside him, Sama Pyo looked distinctly surprised. He silently gave me a thumbs-up.

…You bastard.

Somehow feeling a little pleased and utterly humiliated at the same time, I tried again.

"But there were…circumstances."

"Taishan knows! Taishan knows the circumstances! Taishan knows what that is!"

"Shut your mouth, you bastard!"

Ah.

Taishan had been bouncing with excitement, but shrank back at my thunderous shout. For some reason, Namho was still perched on his shoulders, riding him like a human throne. He spoke with a serious expression.

"But when are you going to take that hand out?"

Straight to the heart of it.

I kept my cool.

"I was just waiting for the right moment."

"Mm. In a situation like this, it can't be easy to pull it out."

"Thank you for understanding."

"Still, there are a lot of eyes on you. You should take it out now. Quickly, not slowly."

"May I ask why?"

“The slower you move, the longer they’ll watch. I’ll count to three. Take it out exactly on three.”

“That’s a good idea, except I think saying it has drawn even more attention.”

Namho glanced around, then nodded as if I’d made a good point.

“That’s true.”

“Please don’t say anything else. Just for a moment. A very short moment.”

“All right.”

Namho fell silent. I took a small breath, then cautiously addressed the one person standing beside Hyuk Mujin and looking the other way.

“Young Lady Ju.”

The next moment—

Whoosh. Bam!

Ju Hwaran bolted out of the room faster than I’d ever seen her move. Hyuk Mujin came over and patted my shoulder.

“I understand exactly how you feel, Captain.”

“…Shut it.”

“Yes, sir.”

I wished it had just been a dream.

Chapter 931

Everyone needs time alone.

Say, when you need to check the System messages piled up until they're ready to burst, like emails in a portal account you haven't opened in years.

Especially if you've just groped your own private parts in front of a dozen people, then shuddered all over.

But even after that incomprehensible nightmare—and a situation worse than the nightmare itself—people seemed determined not to leave me alone.

"Now, raise your arm and follow my movements."

"Very good. This time, turn it a little farther…"

"How many fingers am I holding up?"

My first visitors were the imperial physicians, who came charging in the moment word spread that I'd regained consciousness.

They'd apparently been standing by for three days under the Emperor's strict orders. Reeking of herbal medicine, they had me do one thing after another, then huddled together with grave expressions and whispered.

Of course, I could hear every word perfectly.

"His condition is normal—no, perfect."

"I heard there was an enormous battle, but he's strangely unharmed. Not a single wound."

"That's not all. If you look more closely, the front of his robe is suspiciously bulging."

"What? You don't mean that's…? No. Impossible."

"To be honest, I'm not certain either. I'll give you a signal when the opportunity arises. You can press it once, pretending it was an accident."

"Hmm. Understood."

Their discussion over, the physicians turned back to me with gentle smiles and suggested one more examination, just in case.

I answered without hesitation.

"Get out. Now."

But even after they left, visitors kept coming to the pavilion where I was staying.

"Um, Captain. You have a visitor."

"Who?"

"Just a moment. They say they were appointed Guanglu Dafu the day before yesterday."

"What exactly does a Guanglu Dafu do?"

"If I knew that, I wouldn't have become a martial artist."

"Sounds like a scammer just from the title. Tell him I'm not taking out a loan."

"Yes, I'll pass that along."

I only learned that the Guanglu Dafu was an official whose rank came just below the Three Excellencies after turning away dozens of officials. Then, at last, I welcomed a new visitor.

"I hope I'm not too late. Judging by the crowds at your door, you're already quite popular."

The voice was warm and familiar. Hong Jin came in joking, and I couldn't help smiling.

"Comrade Hong.[3424]"

"Comrade, hm? Have I ever told you? Even though it was an official title, I always felt I could count on you whenever you called me that, Young Master Jin."

His expression was playful, but his eyes and voice held feelings I couldn't put into words.

"Thank you. Truly. His Highness, the Imperial Younger Brother, couldn't come with me today, but I hope you know he feels the same way."

Swish.

Hong Jin straightened his ornately embroidered navy-blue robe and bowed with the utmost respect. Then he lifted his head and smiled as though nothing had happened.

"Oh, and I got promoted. From now on, everyone's to call me Eunuch Hong, not Comrade Hong."

"Eunuch? You don't mean…?"

"Exactly what you're thinking, Young Master Jin. I felt so guilty and ashamed for suspecting His Majesty all those years without knowing the truth that I turned the position down several times. I even tried to retire to the countryside, but…"

Hong Jin, now dressed in the East Depot uniform I'd grown fairly used to seeing, continued with a faint smile.

"His Majesty said, 'There's so much to take care of. Where do you think you're going, running off on your own? I won't let you go, if only for having the nerve to try.'"

"That's good. Truly."

It was good news, and the right outcome.

Hong Jin could hardly be blamed for the hostility he'd felt toward the Emperor for the past decade or so. The Emperor had deliberately hidden the truth. Besides, keeping Hong Jin at Zhu Bao's side showed just how much he trusted Hong Jin's loyalty.

"So, Comrade Hong—no, Eunuch Hong—are you the East Depot's new Cang Gong?"

[3424] *Dongji* is an official title meaning deputy; it is pronounced like the Korean word for "comrade."

“I’m in charge of the East Depot, yes. But the position of Cang Gong—the Seal-Holding Eunuch—will likely remain vacant forever. The Great Nation leaves no trace of a traitor behind. Besides…”

For a moment, Hong Jin’s eyes turned cold.

“There are still roots we haven’t pulled up.”

I thought I knew what he meant. Broadly, he could mean the entire East Depot, where the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s shadow had fallen most heavily. More narrowly, he could mean the one man whose death was still unconfirmed when I lost consciousness.

“Ma Sanbao.”

Hong Jin gave a small nod at the name.

“We’ve searched the Imperial Capital and hundreds of *li*[3425] around it for three days, but there’s no trace of him. It’s as if he rose straight into the sky.”

Honestly, I couldn’t help admiring Ma Sanbao a little. Escaping that desperate situation was one thing. Evading the Imperial Army’s pursuit for three days afterward was another.

He must have been badly wounded already. How did he disappear?

Of course, it was possible. Ma Sanbao fell far short of his master, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, but he’d still reached the Supreme Peak realm and had monstrous powers of recovery. His disguise technique could change both his face and his build so thoroughly that even I had to marvel at it.

Lastly, he could’ve used a Moving Formation Dark Heaven had hidden somewhere nearby.

Ma Sanbao had to die if we wanted to prevent future trouble. But if he’d already fled beyond our reach, there wasn’t much we could do.

For now, the best we could do was prepare for the prey that hadn’t escaped the net—and the predators approaching from far away with their presence concealed.

“Comrade Hong… no, Eunuch Hong.”

Hong Jin smiled.

“Call me whatever you like. You can, Young Master Jin.”

“Hey, Hong.”

“…You really do make yourself at home. What is it?”

“Can I ask you a favor?”

“Do you even need to ask? I’d do anything for you, Young Master Jin—anything short of treason. Name it.”

“Then…”

He’d answered readily enough, but when he heard my request, his eyes widened.

“Hm?”

[3425] In the Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

“Can’t you do it?”

“No, it’s easy enough. I’m just wondering what it means.”

“It’s important. I’ll explain once I’ve checked it myself.”

“Of course you will. You can’t just expect me to do it for nothing. You’re making use of an East Depot eunuch, after all.”

Hong Jin rose with a joking smile and left. Hyuk Mujin, who’d been watching for an opening, sidled over.

“Um, Captain.”

“You want to know what I asked him to do?”

“Ha! You really are a mind reader.”

He even gave me a thumbs-up, trying to butter me up. I let out a short laugh and shook my head.

“There is something.”

“Wait, you’re keeping it secret from me too?”

“It’s not exactly that…”

“Not exactly?”

“I don’t know either.”

“…?”

Hyuk Mujin stared at me, thoroughly unimpressed.

“If you don’t want to tell me, just say so. Don’t make me feel even more pathetic.”

“I’m serious, you idiot.”

“Forget it. Don’t talk to me for a while. I won’t talk to you either.”

He made a show of his hurt feelings as he headed for the door. I called after him apologetically.

“Back to your spot before I count to three. One.”

Whoosh.

Hyuk Mujin returned to his spot before I could count to two, then asked while pretending to look elsewhere,

“So, what is it?”

“I told you. I don’t know exactly what it is either.”

“…Really?”

“Yeah. Someone told me about it, but only in broad strokes.”

“Who?”

“Someone you know, too.”

Hyuk Mujin cocked his head, then thumped his chest confidently.

“Tell me who it is, and I’ll bring them here right away. Then you can hear all about it in greater detail…”

“That won’t work.”

I cut him off.

“That person’s already dead.”

“What?”

“Dead. I killed him myself.”

Hyuk Mujin stared at me with his mouth hanging open. Then his eyes went wide.

“Y-you don’t mean…? No, right?”

“I told you. Now go and leave me alone.”

“Wait. Why would that bastard tell you—?”

“Get out before I count to three. Whatever happens after that is your problem. One.”

Whoosh.

Works like a charm.

I gave a hollow laugh at the empty spot where he’d been. He’d vanished before I could count to two.

Then I sank into the soft silk bedding and gazed out the window. It was bright enough outside to make it hard to believe it was night.

Bright. Noisy, too.

Even from this pavilion deep inside the Inner Palace, I could hear distant cheers and songs carried on the wind.

Fireworks shot up here and there, painting the night sky in brilliant colors. The people, welcoming a new era, would have forgotten sleep and poured into the streets, laughing, talking, and drinking all night.

Leaving tomorrow’s worries behind to enjoy today’s happiness to the fullest.

You wanted a world like this once, too.

I thought of someone no longer in this world.

A man who had let go of all the anger left in his heart at the very end and died as a human being. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

And the Sound Transmission that had been all but his last words.

Remember every word I say from this moment on.

What followed was short and simple.

Find one thing in a certain place.

That was all.

And I’d find out what that thing was soon enough.

I didn’t know either. I had no idea what that thing was, the one the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had mentioned at the very end, or what it contained or meant.

But I’d decided to stop thinking about it until I saw it with my own eyes. I had other things to deal with right now.

“Open System window.”

The quiet words had barely left my lips when—
Ding. Ding. D-d-ding!
Chimes rang out like mad, and countless holographic windows filled my vision.
For a very long time.
As if they'd been waiting for this moment all along.

Chapter 932

"Open System window."

At that brief command, the dam holding everything back gave way.

Ding. Ding. D-d-ding!

Chimes rang out, one over another. At the same time, countless holographic windows surged toward me like a giant wave. My mouth fell open.

Holy shit. Why are there so many?

It felt like facing all the homework I'd put off over an entire summer vacation in elementary school. No—this was worse.

Even at a glance, well over a hundred holographic windows filled the air.

It'd be nice if they were all Level-up notifications.

Wishful thinking, of course. There was no way they'd all piled up in just the past three days.

I started with the first System message to appear and read them in order.

> **System** Congratulations! The Update is complete!
> We sincerely regret any minor inconvenience caused by the Update.

"…"

Minor inconvenience. Sincere regret.

What a way to piss me off right from the start.

I vividly remembered nearly dying because of that "minor inconvenience." But the next message quickly cooled my anger.

> **System** Therefore, as an apology, we would like to provide you with an appropriate Reward.

"Oh."

Right. That's more like it.

This System was fundamentally different from those garbage games that wielded the Four Great Swords—scheduled maintenance, unscheduled maintenance, extended maintenance, and emergency maintenance—like an heirloom blade.

Giving users fitting Rewards for all their hard work and doing everything it could to make their experience enjoyable—that was what a kingly, god-tier System was for.

> **System** Update Reward has been delivered to your Inventory.

> Would you like to check your new Item?
> **Y / N**

Reward. New Item.

Those two little words awakened the childlike wonder I'd long forgotten.

I was more excited than I'd been opening my Christmas present at seven years old. With excitement and joy mingling inside me, I answered.

"Open."

Ding.

> **System Item Window**
> Pocket Watch of Unknown Make
> **Type:** Item
> **Grade:** None
> **Restriction:** None
> **Description:** A pocket watch made by someone unknown. Very sturdy. At a glance, it looks like an old, broken watch. On closer inspection, it still looks like an old, broken watch.

"…?"

What the hell is this?

My brain stalled. I stared blankly at the pocket watch in my hand.

It was exactly as the Item description said. At a glance, it looked broken. On closer inspection, it still looked broken. I could've written a poem about it on the spot.

Title: Pocket Watch.

Old, even on closer inspection.

Broken, no matter how long I look.

Fucking sucks.

"…"

I felt like I was going insane.

It was on par with the betrayal I'd felt when Santa Claus—the old man who'd brought my Christmas present when I was seven—had punched in the front door's passcode and strolled in like he owned the place, then kissed my mom right in front of me.

This is my… Update Reward?

My head still reeling, I tried to pull myself out of the shock.

No, no. This can't be right.

There were only two possibilities. Either the System had prepared a surprise hidden-camera prank for me after everything I'd been through, or there was something special about the watch that I hadn't found yet.

There was only one notification, so it's not a prank. Which means…

I gathered my wits and examined the watch carefully. Before long, I noticed something I'd missed on its back, worn shiny by someone's hands.

Wait.

It was a faint mark, almost completely rubbed away—probably too faint for an ordinary person to see. I stirred up my internal energy and channeled it into my eyes. With my enhanced vision, I made out a dim inscription.

"N-no way…"

> Even a broken clock is right twice a day.

"That doesn't mean a damn thing, you bastards!"

BANG!

I hurled the pocket watch with all my strength. It flew like a cannonball and struck the wall.

Or, to be precise, it smashed through the wall.

Rumble!

The wall crumbled. Beyond it stood Hyuk Mujin, staring at me with his mouth hanging open.

"What the—Gasp! Was that an assassination attempt?!"

In a way, it was.

I'd taken a hit to the back of the head without warning, and now my insides ached as if I'd been stabbed.

"Mujin. I'm dizzy. Mujin."

"Captain! Stay still! I'll protect you!"

"You? Protect me?"

Hyuk Mujin hesitated, then cautiously offered, "Should I bring Great Hero Jeok over?"

"…If you call him, we're the ones who'll get put through the wringer. Don't."

"Oh, come on. You scared me. It wasn't an assassination attempt, right?"

"Yeah, idiot. So quit making a scene and pick that thing up."

Coughing in the cloud of dust, Hyuk Mujin cautiously retrieved the pocket watch.

"C-Captain. You don't mean this piece of iron junk, do you?"

"…"

"Sorry. I guess you do. And, just in case, I take back the 'junk' part."

Like an unlucky member of the Ten Attendants,[3426] Hyuk Mujin sensed my foul mood and hurried over to hand me the watch.

"But what exactly is it?"

"A broken watch."

"A watch? This little thing?"

Hyuk Mujin eyed the pocket watch's unfamiliar shape. I answered mournfully.

"It's still junk. Very sturdy, completely useless junk."

"Why would you keep something like this? It's even broken."

"…I got it somehow, okay? Watch your mouth."

Every word was a blade digging into my heart. Having confirmed the watch's durability by accident, I swallowed back my tears.

The Item description was telling the truth after all.

Some truths were unbearably cruel. Right now, this pocket watch was one of them.

But why would the System give me something like this?

This wasn't some ordinary Quest. It was the Reward I'd received for completing an entire Update, and it was garbage like this.

Clinging to one last sliver of hope, I examined the watch again. All I found was more reason to despair.

This thing really is broken.

For starters, the time was completely wrong. It was already nearing midnight, but the hour hand pointed somewhere around five. Even that was only a guess—the numbers that ought to have been there were missing.

And where the hell did the minute hand go?

At this point, I wasn't sure I could even call it a pocket watch. Pocket time? Pocket piece? Even those seemed too generous.

I can't adjust the time, either. And it doesn't seem to keep moving. What the hell is this thing?

I shook it this way and that, then held it close to my ear. There wasn't so much as a tick—not even the faint noise of parts moving inside.

It had exactly one advantage. I couldn't crush it no matter how hard I squeezed, or even leave a scratch.

Did they give it to me as a weapon? Or a shield for emergencies?

A familiar scene from a war movie flashed through my mind.

A sharp gunshot rang out. Private Johnson collapsed.

Certain their comrade was dead, his squadmates rushed over. But what they found was a bullet lodged in the little Bible that the devout Private Johnson always carried over his heart…

[3426] The Ten Attendants were powerful eunuch officials in imperial China.

"Wow. It's already driving me insane."

Hyuk Mujin, who'd been watching me warily for a while, cautiously spoke up.

"Um, Captain?"

"Don't call me in that sly, eunuch-like voice. I'll kill you. Seriously."

"Yes, sir. May I ask you something?"

"Spit it out."

"Um… are you going to throw that away?"

Hyuk Mujin pointed discreetly at the pocket watch in my palm, then went on as though he were making casual conversation.

"If you are, I'd like to humbly suggest giving it to someone who's your right arm, your heart, and unwaveringly loyal to you."

"Was that supposed to be humble? You sound pretty confident."

"Well, I'm just saying. If you're not going to use it, there's no reason to keep it."

"Why the hell do you want this thing?"

"It's a watch, isn't it? And judging by the look of it, it's a rare item from the Western Regions. Even if it's broken, wouldn't it look good to carry around?"

Hyuk Mujin made a surprisingly coherent argument. I smacked my lips.

I guess it wouldn't really matter if I gave it to him…

But something about it bothered me, like a fish bone stuck in my throat. If I handed this godforsaken pocket watch to Hyuk Mujin right now, I'd feel even less satisfied than I would eating fried rice at a Chinese restaurant without a bowl of spicy jjambbong[3427] broth.

There might be something I don't know about it yet. I can wait and see. If it really is junk, I can give it to him then.

It wasn't as if the System always gave out incredible Rewards. I didn't know exactly how it decided what to hand out, but I'd received plenty of useless junk Items from the countless Quests I'd completed. Little by little, enough had piled up in my Inventory to fill a truck.

The one thing I couldn't get past was that the broken pocket watch in my hand was a Reward for completing an Update.

"Hmm."

I nodded without saying anything. Then Hyuk Mujin's sly voice reached my ear again.

"Um, Captain?"

"What?"

"Could you say something…?"

"Not yet. Wait a little. A month—no, fifteen days."

[3427] Jjambbong is a Korean-Chinese spicy noodle soup, often made with seafood.

Fifteen days. Half a month.

That was the final trial period I'd settled on. Hyuk Mujin's face lit up.

"So you'll give it to me in fifteen days?"

"Yeah. Assuming I've confirmed it's useless to me."

"Come on. It came from the Western Regions. There probably isn't a craftsman around here who can fix it. At most, you could carry it because it looks pretty."

Hyuk Mujin grinned unpleasantly as he went on.

"But what do you call it?"

"Pocket-watch, shi—pocket watch."

"Wow. Even the name's pretty. Thread a leather cord through that ring and wear it around your neck. You'd draw eyes wherever you went."

"Yeah?"

"Yes. Shiny silk would look even better than leather."

"Oh, yeah?"

It was a suggestion worthy of the eldest grandson of a wealthy textile-merchant family. It was a good one, too. Without hesitation, I tore a strip from the gold silk robe I was wearing, threaded it through the ring, and hung the watch around my neck.

"How do I look? Pretty?"

"Whew. Is your name Mr. Golden Sun? You're practically glowing."

"They'd like it if I gave it to them like this, wouldn't they?"

"Captain, you'd go that far for me…"

Hyuk Mujin's eyes trembled with emotion. I gazed fondly at the pocket watch hanging around my neck.

"Not you. Young Lady Ju."

"…"

"Maybe Young Lady Ju would be less upset if she got a gift like this. Don't you think?"

"…"

"Answer me."

"…I'm sure she'd love it. Yes."

His eyes went cold in an instant.

As Hyuk Mujin silently berated me with his gaze, I sensed dozens of people approaching the pavilion. I leaned out the window.

"Stop! Stop! Stop! Move and I'll cut you down. Pocket!"

At the head of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, their torches flickering, Jeong Hogun fell silent for a moment before replying.

"What nonsense are you talking about?"

“You stupid, useless Embroidered Uniform Guard bastard! You showed up without even learning the password!”

“No, I mean, what is this all of a sudden…?”

“Shut up! Say ‘watch’! Hurry!”

“…Watch.”

“I said shut up!”

“…”

His eyes were full of venom, like an angry pufferfish. I supposed I’d better stop messing with him.

Generously letting him off the hook, I asked Jeong Hogun, who’d clamped his mouth shut, “So, why are you here?”

“You need to come with me for a moment.”

“Am I someone who comes and goes just because you tell me to? Besides, I’m really busy. I’ve got a lot to do.”

“His Majesty has summoned you.”

“Oh.”

Then I’d better go.

Chapter 933

I followed Jeong Hogun, taking a careful look around as we went.

I'd expected some dramatic change, but the Imperial Palace looked much the same as it had on my first visit.

Palace attendants in neat uniforms hurried back and forth, while heavily armed Embroidered Uniform Guards stood watch at their posts like iron towers.

If anything had changed, it was me.

Swish.

When a group of palace attendants approaching from the other direction bowed deeply as they passed, I thought it was a coincidence.

Clank.

Even when the Embroidered Uniform Guards struck their armor and saluted, I didn't think much of it. Jeong Hogun had considerable pull among the Guard, so it seemed only natural that they'd salute him.

"Guess being a Thousand Captain means you can throw your weight around, huh?"

Jeong Hogun's reply to my joking remark was utterly calm.

"You're less observant than you look."

"Hm?"

"They aren't paying their respects because I'm here."

Only then did it hit me. Only then did I see it.

The people passing us were looking at me. The gratitude and respect in their eyes were meant for me alone.

"Uh…"

What was I supposed to say?

I was still at a loss for words when Jeong Hogun came to an abrupt halt.

No—not just him. Everyone who'd come with him stopped at the same time.

Step.

They moved as one, with a heavy ring of metal.

Jeong Hogun glanced at the plaque reading *Qianqing Palace* a dozen or so jang[3428] ahead, then turned to me.

"I don't know when we'll see each other again, so I should say this now."

The sharp eyes beneath his low-pulled helmet softened, curving like a crescent moon.

"It was an honor to fight alongside you, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung."

[3428] A jang is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

"…!"

I stared at him, eyes wide.

Jeong Hogun had never bowed to anyone but the Emperor. Now his rigid back and neck inclined toward me as he offered a deeply respectful fist-and-palm salute.

"Until we meet again, I wish you good fortune in battle."

"We wish you good fortune!"

Shing! Shing! Shing!

Dozens of Embroidered Uniform Guards echoed him and drew their swords, gripping them in reverse.

They stood in two neat rows on either side of the path to Qianqing Palace. I couldn't help laughing.

"Come on, you're making me blush."

But I stopped laughing almost at once and returned their salute, bringing my hands together.

"We'll meet again. We will."

I meant it. That was enough.

No one knew when we'd meet again. I'd leave everything else until then. Every meeting and every bond came with a parting, after all.

Step. Step.

I walked slowly down the path Jeong Hogun and the guards had made for me.

Beneath the high eaves of Qianqing Palace, the twin armed guards were waiting. Thanks to a new scar, I could finally tell their faces apart.

As I climbed the stairs, they quietly stepped aside, as though there were no formalities to observe.

The enormous iron door they guarded stood wide open, unlike the last time I'd visited.

Qianqing Palace stood in the deepest part of the Imperial Palace.

And in the innermost chamber of Qianqing Palace, the Emperor was waiting for me.

"Oh, you're here."

His voice was gentler than before, warm with welcome. His eyes were smiling too.

But even faced with such a welcome from the Emperor—a man called Iron Blood for the countless purges and ruthless decisions he'd made since before taking the throne—I didn't smile.

No. I couldn't.

Why?

I hadn’t said it aloud, but my bewilderment must have shown. The Emperor watched me struggle for words, then gave a quiet laugh and spoke first.

“You seem rather taken aback. Understandable, I suppose, when the Son of Heaven looks like this.”

He tapped the bandages wrapped around his upper body. The faint smile on his lips made his sunken cheeks stand out even more.

“A piece of advice: at times like this, lower your head first.”

He was impossibly gaunt compared to just three days ago. I was still shaken, but I forced myself to reply calmly.

“Is there a reason for that?”

“Two. You can hide your expression, and you buy yourself a moment to think.”

“I see. I might as well try it.”

I lowered my head, then lifted it again less than ten seconds later.

“You’ve already seen my expression, so it’s too late to hide that. But the time to think does help.”

“May I ask what you thought about?”

“Why Your Majesty looks like this. What caused it.”

“A waste of thought. I simply overexerted myself in that battle.”

The Emperor smiled and waved a hand. The smile vanished when he heard my next words.

“So you’ve been smoking poppy again?”

“…!”

“I was slow to notice. The sight of you caught me off guard, and I didn’t pay attention to the smell.”

I drew a slow breath as I watched his face go rigid. The strong, peculiar scent that reached me was unmistakably the one I remembered.

“How long… have you known?”

His voice had dropped. I thought back to the first time I’d entered Qianqing Palace: the strangely familiar scent I’d noticed when I finally met the Emperor, and the moment someone who occasionally smoked poppy had helped me place it.

“I didn’t know at first.”

“I can’t imagine how you figured it out. It isn’t easy to obtain, and I’ve heard Murim practitioners avoid anything that harms the mind and spirit.”

“You heard right. Murim practitioners generally do.”

I added calmly, “But I hear eunuchs sometimes use it.”

“…Hong Jin, then.”

A wound, once inflicted, has a long shelf life.

Whether it's psychological or physical, the mind and body remember. Old wounds can still ache decades later, even after the scars have faded. How much worse must it be for eunuchs, who've had their private parts cut off?

Hong Jin was no exception. When the pain came without warning and he couldn't bear it, he turned to poppy. Thanks to him, I'd stumbled onto one of the Emperor's secrets.

"How long have you been using it? And why?"

"I don't see why you need to know."

Before I could respond, the Emperor gave a bitter smile and pointed to his head.

"Besides, nothing I say will change much."

"…No way."

He seemed to have already given up. And that gesture had meaning, too.

I stared at him, eyes wide, as he parted his dry lips.

"That's right. It's what you're thinking."

"…!"

"The Blood Soul Gu. That cursed poison has reached my very marrow."

My suspicion hardened into certainty, and a curse escaped me like a groan.

"Damn it."

"Impertinent. Such vulgar language before the father of all the people? If Commander Baek were here, he'd have you dragged to prison at once."

Someone else might have trembled and begged forgiveness. I only sighed at the Emperor, who was making a show of frowning.

"Is this really the time for jokes?"

"Have I ever told you I'm good at them?"

"This is the first I've heard of it. You're so bad it gives me goose bumps."

"That's because you're a dull fellow. Back when I was campaigning, I'd drink and laugh with my men every night. Those were good times."

"I hate to say this to a critically ill man, but you were probably the only one having fun."

"That can't be. Every time I said something, they'd laugh until they doubled over."

"…I see."

I didn't know who those men had been, but they must have worked hard to laugh along.

Not that it mattered right now.

I shook my head at the clueless division commander—no, Emperor—and asked what I most wanted to know.

"When did it start?"

"More than ten years ago. Just after the coup, to be exact."

As though there was nothing left to hide, the Emperor continued calmly.

"A loyal servant I trusted did it. By the time I realized, it was too late."

"Who among Your Majesty's closest people knows?"

"Only two. Baek Yeon and So Gyo. Though perhaps I should call her the Bow Saint now."

He looked at me and added, "And today, one more person has learned a truth that must never be known."

I caught his meaning at once and clicked my tongue.

"Are you going to kill me to keep me quiet?"

"If I tried, would you let me?"

"Not a chance. I'm going to live until I'm so old I'm smearing shit on the walls."

"Then I'm better off than you. As Emperor, I can't make such a disgrace of myself."

He gave a soft chuckle. Then, without warning, he coughed.

Cough.

His golden sleeve stained red. I looked around, my face hardening at the sudden spitting of blood, but the Emperor shook his head before I could move.

"Don't bother."

"Bother with what?"

"If you're thinking of calling an imperial physician, don't."

"…"

"If they could cure this, I'd have done something about it long ago. Why do you think I hid it even from them?"

The Emperor gazed at his blood-soaked sleeve and murmured as if to himself.

"My father and mother. My three elder brothers. The senior members of the imperial family who worked so faithfully to uphold the ancestral shrines and the state… Not one was spared. None escaped death."

He was right. No one had escaped the Blood Soul Gu's grasp.

That was why his attempt to set everything right after the coup had failed. The late Emperor, the Empress, and several direct members of the imperial family, including the Crown Prince, had died one after another. The Fourth Prince who'd started the coup had been branded an unforgivable, unfilial son and a usurper.

"I have no regrets left. I took every elixir I could to stay alive and trained in martial arts at a bone-grinding pace to withstand the Blood Soul Gu's poison. I held on like that for ten years."

At last, I understood why he—the man who held the greatest territory in the world and commanded countless troops—had reached his current realm.

"After enduring a winter of more than ten years, spring has finally come. That's enough for me."

At that moment, a clear smile rested on the Emperor's lips.

Chapter 934

Winter comes for everyone.

But the winter one man—an emperor, or rather a man named Zhu Di—had to endure was exceptionally harsh.

More than ten long years.

For all that time, long enough for the world to change beyond recognition, he fought illness. He had to learn martial arts just to stay alive, and with the blades of rebellion lurking on every side, not a single day passed when he could sleep easy.

Spring, regained after such a long wait.

The Emperor smiled bitterly.

At last, the long winter had ended and warm spring had come. Yet he still shivered with cold.

“I was prepared for this. Have been for a long time. So…”

The Emperor murmured the words calmly, then fixed his gaze on the young man before him.

“You don’t need to look at me like that.”

Someone had once said there was beauty in the sight of a person who had given their all.

But there was nothing beautiful about someone wasting away after giving everything they had.

The sight stirred only a bitter feeling that was hard to name.

That was the look in the eyes of the young man staring at the Emperor now: Jin Taekyung.

“How much time do you have left?”

“That’s a question for the heavens.”

“This isn’t the time for jokes.”

“Did it sound like a joke?”

“…!”

“Even making it this far is a miracle. If I hadn’t learned martial arts, and if I hadn’t had the help of Baek Yeon and the Bow Saint, I’d already be dead.”

The vitality and physical strength of a Supreme Peak master were beyond comparison with those of ordinary people.

That was why the Emperor had learned martial arts—not to become stronger for its own sake, but solely to survive.

He had to grow stronger to resist the Blood Soul Gu’s poison.

But even the precious time he had bought himself was now drawing to a close.

“Not long ago, I found myself wondering something. If I’d been born with martial talent like yours, perhaps I could’ve completely suppressed the Blood Soul Gu.”

“Don’t talk like you’re helpless. Making it this far is already incredible. If you don’t give up and keep working at it…”

“Do you really believe that? Honestly, without the slightest bit of pity or a single lie?”

Jin Taekyung was at a loss for words. The Emperor continued, his voice calm.

“I don’t need half-hearted comfort. I know reality better than anyone.”

Despite having been taught by two peerless masters—the Bow Saint and Baek Yeon—and having absorbed all manner of elixirs, he had only reached the early stage of Supreme Peak.

Of course, the Blood Soul Gu’s poison had made learning martial arts no easy task. But the fact that even bone-deep effort and the finest possible conditions hadn’t brought him any further meant one thing.

A limit.

This was as far as he could go.

The Emperor had neither the talent to break through the enormous wall in front of him nor the time to do it.

Ka-koff. Koff.

The Emperor’s complexion was pale as he let out a series of small coughs. That was when Jin Taekyung’s quiet voice reached him.

“What if there’s still… a chance?”

“A chance.”

It was a word he hadn’t heard in a long time.

And the Emperor already knew what Taekyung meant by it.

“It’s too soon to give up.”

“Yes, I suppose you could think that. You trust the Divine Physician that much.”

“…!”

“Now that I think about it, there were three of you, not two. Three people who knew about my condition.”

At the sight of Jin Taekyung frozen with wide eyes, the Emperor gave a quiet laugh.

“He came to see me three days ago.”

Taekyung fell silent.

There was no need to ask how the examination had gone. Everything the Emperor had said and done until now was proof enough.

“He said it was too late. He shook his head and said there was nothing he could do for me right now.”

It was the judgment of the Divine Physician, whose medical skill was the greatest under heaven.

Unless the Great Firmament Immortal himself intervened, it was as good as confirmation that no human being could overcome this illness.

“And yet, all of a sudden, I felt ridiculous.”

The Emperor continued with a bitter smile.

“I thought I’d prepared myself and accepted everything long ago. But when the Divine Physician confirmed it, I felt as though a part of my chest had gone hollow.”

At last, spring had come.

No—he had reclaimed spring.

He had lived fiercely, and he wanted to keep doing so.

But he didn’t have much time left.

“Earlier, I told you I had no regrets left. That I was content.”

Taekyung finally spoke.

“I know. I knew you didn’t mean it.”

“Yes. You’re right. It was all a complete lie.”

The Emperor breathed heavily.

The crushing pressure on his chest, as if an enormous boulder were weighing it down, wasn’t caused only by the Blood Soul Gu that had eaten away at his body and mind over the years.

“There’s… so much I have to take care of before I die.”

The Emperor knew.

The spring he’d fought so hard to reclaim, its warmth, was only a passing spring breeze—a brief respite.

Before long, a cold frost would fall over the land and cover it all.

“There will be a war. One more brutal and vast than any before it.”

The calm before the storm.

Four characters that described the present situation more accurately than anything else.

And the weight of that coming storm would fall on whoever stood as ruler of the continent after the Emperor.

“Bao’er.”

One name slipped from the Emperor’s dry lips.

Prince Shangshan. No—the Imperial Younger Brother, Zhu Bao.

His last lingering attachment, the one who made him look back again and again as he neared the end of his life. His own flesh and blood, so precious he could never bear to see him hurt.

The little boy who wasn’t here had become a great boulder pressing down on the Emperor’s chest.

"He'll surely become a sage king. He'll be loved and praised by all the people, and bring peace and prosperity to this land."

But peace had already been broken.

To survive the flames of war that would sweep across the continent, the boy would have to become a conqueror, not a sage king.

"That burden will be too much for him."

The Emperor knew better than anyone how heavy and overwhelming the title *Son of Heaven* could be.

Perhaps by the heavens' grace, his youngest brother had been born with the qualities of a sage king. But he was still far too young.

Too young to rule a nation.

And too young to weather a war.

I want to live. I still have things to do for that boy, for this country and its people.

The Emperor said it only in his heart.

He knew reality wouldn't change no matter how desperately he wished it would, so he swallowed the words. As the ruler, who must never waver, he couldn't say them aloud.

What's the point of lamenting? It's all futile anyway.

The Emperor gave a bitter laugh. That was when—

"Did you know?"

Jin Taekyung spoke up without warning, fixing his gaze on the Emperor as he continued.

"There are two main ways to piss someone off. The first is to start saying something and then stop, and the second is…"

His voice trailed off, and silence followed.

The Emperor waited patiently for the rest. Then he couldn't hold back any longer.

"The second is what?"

"Hm?"

"I asked what the second one is."

"Oh, that."

Taekyung blinked as though he'd just remembered something he'd forgotten long ago, then scratched his chin.

"I just won't tell you. Let's move on."

"…What?"

"What does it matter? You didn't finish what you were saying, either."

"What are you talking about—"

The Emperor was so dumbfounded he was about to continue, but Taekyung spoke first.

“Just be honest. Say you want to live.”

“…!”

“Is that so hard?”

The Emperor’s pupils trembled.

It wasn’t because of Taekyung’s outrageous disrespect.

It was the embarrassment of having the truth he’d kept so tightly hidden laid bare, as if he’d been stripped naked.

“I am… the Son of Heaven.”

“So what? The Son of Heaven isn’t a person?”

“That’s enough!”

The Emperor’s low shout didn’t faze Taekyung. His words came in a rush.

“When someone says something hurtful, it hurts. When you get cut by a blade, you bleed. When you’re facing a hard reality, you lose heart. It’s the same for everyone. What’s different about wearing golden silk embroidered with dragons and looking down on all the civil and military officials?”

“…”

“You said you didn’t need half-hearted comfort. Fine. I won’t give you any. But you need to be more honest, too. Forget being the Emperor or anything else—just act like a person for a little while.”

The Emperor, his face clouded with confusion, wondered to himself:

Why had he summoned Jin Taekyung here today? Why had he let out thoughts he’d never shared with anyone?

And why, after such insolence, did he feel no anger?

Then he let out a quiet laugh.

“Do you know something?”

“I don’t. Except that you’re feeling better than I expected.”

“But I haven’t even said anything yet.”

“That’s why I said I don’t know. I’d have to hear it to know. How could I know if I haven’t heard it?”

“Ha! Ha-ha-ha!”

The Emperor suddenly burst into loud laughter. Before long, he coughed up blood and muttered,

“Damn it.”

“I didn’t know you knew how to swear.”

“You said the Son of Heaven was a person, didn’t you?”

“Oh. Yeah, I did.”

“…Still, don’t drop the formalities.”

“I was talking to myself.”

“What do you think would happen if I muttered to myself that you’d just tried to assassinate me?”

“That wouldn’t work. That’d be spreading false information.”

“You made me cough up blood, so it wouldn’t be entirely false.”

“You’ve got a real talent for twisting things.”

“This is getting more and more absurd. Is that any way to speak to the father of all the people and the Emperor of the Great Nation?”

“Dad.”

“What?”

“You said you were a father. If you don’t like me calling you Dad, I’ll call you Mom.”

“What kind of madman are you?”

The Emperor laughed so hard he could barely breathe. Still grinning, he spoke again.

“Do you know what I was about to say a moment ago?”

“You mean the thing I said I didn’t know?”

“That’s right.”

“Not really.”

“We—no, I…”

The Emperor stared at Taekyung, who was still playing coy, then slowly parted his lips.

“I want to live. More desperately than anyone.”

Jin Taekyung grinned.

“Now you sound like a person.”

“But reality hasn’t changed. I didn’t want to make a pitiful spectacle of myself.”

“So, are you crying now?”

“Where did that come from all of a sudden—”

“I cried. Three days ago.”

Despite what he was saying, Taekyung’s voice held a hint of laughter.

“I’m not exaggerating one bit. I bawled my eyes out, with snot running everywhere. I writhed around like a grub and begged the heavens to save me. I told them I still had so much left to do. That there were precious people I absolutely had to see one more time.”

“…!”

“I must’ve looked too pathetic to bear watching. But I wasn’t ashamed of myself.”

He’d fought to stay alive, and survived.

That was how he’d been given a second chance. How he’d ended up here.

“You don’t need to be ashamed, and you don’t need to despair.”

Jin Taekyung held out his hand to the Emperor.
“I’ll save you, one way or another.”

Chapter 935

"I heard Jin Taekyung came by."

The Emperor sat alone in his vast bedchamber, lost in thought. The man's sudden voice didn't startle him.

Baek Yeon was one of the very few—perhaps the only person—who could come and go anywhere in Qianqing Palace without asking permission.

"You're a step too late, Baek Yeon. He left half a shichen[3429] ago."

"That doesn't matter. I came to see Your Majesty."

At Commander Baek Yeon's calm reply, the Emperor affected a frown.

"I'd rather you hadn't. I've seen enough of your face already."

"Then have you been well these past three days?"

"What kind of question is that? It's been a relief not having a nag around."

"I'm hurt."

"Don't sulk. Someone who used to watch me day and night is in much the same position as you."

"No Shadow would be even more hurt if he heard that."

"That's why I'm saying it while he's away. He's no longer my bodyguard, so I can talk behind his back now and then."

"Well. There's no winning against Your Majesty."

Baek Yeon shook his head in defeat, and the Emperor gave a quiet laugh.

"So, is Bao'er doing well?"

"Of course. He couldn't be better."

But the worry didn't leave the Emperor's face.

"He's been through so much at such a young age. His mind and body must still be unsettled. Stay by his side."

Baek Yeon heard the concern in his voice. He understood it, too.

The Emperor's own flesh and blood had returned after more than a decade. Though it had been for the boy's safety, his youngest brother had, in effect, been left on his own. No amount of love or worry could feel like enough now.

Why else would the Emperor have assigned both No Shadow, his hidden bodyguard, and Baek Yeon, his closest confidant, directly to the Imperial Younger Brother?

Look after the boy. I can trust you two with him.

Remembering the request the Emperor had made three days ago—a request, not an order—Baek Yeon spoke.

[3429] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“His Highness isn’t even fifteen yet, but of everyone I’ve met, only one person has a stronger, more upright spirit. It’s hard to believe he’s so young.”

“Only one?”

“Your Majesty.”

The answer came without hesitation. For a moment, the Emperor was at a loss for words. Then he raised both hands.

“I concede. Flattery from you, of all people. You’ve changed, Baek Yeon.”

“That’s true. Much like how Your Majesty has started making jokes.”

“Come now. I said I conceded. Enough nonsense.”

“Did what I just said sound like flattery or nonsense?”

Baek Yeon smiled faintly.

“I meant it. I’ve always admired and respected Your Majesty. Others would have given up on that thorn-covered road many times over, but you kept going, even with your feet covered in blood.”

The sincerity in his words left the Emperor silent.

Something welled up and caught in his throat. For the moment, he could barely speak. He fought the feeling down and forced out a reply.

“If I’d had to walk that road alone, I would have given up along the way. I couldn’t have done it without you all.”

“I don’t believe that.”

Baek Yeon shook his head and continued slowly.

“We could trust and follow you because you were who you are. This day was only possible because Your Majesty bore the greatest responsibility and the greatest pain.”

“…!”

“Even while watching for traitors hiding their blades, did you ever neglect the affairs of state? I watched you sacrifice sleep to practice martial arts, handle petitions, and fight your illness—all at once.”

A jumble of emotions crossed the Emperor’s face.

Yes. That was how it had been. There had been days when it could be no other way.

“It was only natural. Sleep was a luxury.”

For more than ten years, he had never slept more than one shichen[3430] a day.

No—even that sleep had never been peaceful. He had to keep his mind alert while he felt his body slowly dying.

That was what it meant to be the Son of Heaven. From the highest position under heaven, he had to face the fiercest storms before anyone else, while watching over and caring for all that lay beneath him.

[3430] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

That was how the Emperor saw his duty. And it was why Baek Yeon respected him so deeply.

“Deciding to do something is as easy as turning over your hand. Following through is as hard as moving a mountain.”

At first, Baek Yeon hadn’t been certain either.

Could the Great Nation’s fourth prince, their last remaining choice, join them in their great undertaking? Was he fit to hold the Son of Heaven’s absolute power?

But he had proved himself. Better than anyone.

Though the Imperial treasury was piled high with mountains of gold and silver, he had always lived frugally. Though peerlessly beautiful women had been presented before him, he had never indulged in women. He had even chosen not to produce an heir, for fear of putting his youngest brother in danger.

That way, Dark Heaven couldn’t harm Zhu Bao. They couldn’t recklessly kill a child with the legitimacy to replace the Emperor, nor could they inject him with Blood Soul Gu, which would swiftly kill its host.

“Every one of the things Your Majesty considered only natural was anything but.”

“…!”

The Emperor’s eyelids trembled at Baek Yeon’s quiet words.

He hadn’t known. He hadn’t known Baek Yeon thought of him that way.

Looking back over the road he’d traveled, the Emperor realized he wasn’t the only one who had kept his true feelings hidden. Baek Yeon had, too.

“I… don’t know what to say.”

At the strain in the Emperor’s voice, Baek Yeon let out a hearty laugh.

“You don’t have to say anything.”

“Shouldn’t I say something?”

“I’m not sure. It might only make things more awkward.”

The Emperor shook his head, then clicked his tongue.

“Baek Yeon, are you really the man I’ve always known?”

“What on earth do you mean?”

“Do you have to ask? You’ve always been merciless.”

“Are you talking about when you were learning martial arts?”

“I am. You said, ‘Please forgive me for laying hands on Your Majesty’s precious body,‘ then proceeded to beat me all over.”

“Why bring that up all of a sudden?”

Baek Yeon frowned at the unexpected reminder.

“And as I told you then, you improve at martial arts by getting hit. So Gyo… I mean, the Bow Saint agreed with me, didn’t she?”

“She did. The two of you even teamed up to beat me later. It hurt so much I spent ages wondering whether to quit on the spot.”

“Did I threaten you with a sword? You were the one who asked me to teach you.”

“And there’s the way you speak to me. Whenever I struggled, you’d come by and lay into me without fail. You’d even use the familiar *hao* form, as if you’d forgotten how one addresses the Son of Heaven.”

“That was…”

Baek Yeon trailed off and glanced away at the empty air.

He could excuse laying hands on the Emperor during martial arts training as part of teaching him. This was different. Even if he had meant to encourage the Emperor, some of the things he’d said and done had been anything but proper conduct for a subject.

“Your Majesty, I—”

“Don’t pretend you’ve forgotten. You were doing it until quite recently. Only a few days after Bao’er entered the palace, you came to me and gave me a thorough tongue-lashing.”

“You were taking poppy with our great undertaking so close at hand. I was afraid it would ruin your mind and body.”

“What does that have to do with using the familiar form of address? I’d been bedridden and suffering for days, and had only just recovered some strength. I had to take poppy to ease the pain, even a little.”

“I know. I knew then, too, but I was worried about you, Your Majesty.”

Baek Yeon kept speaking while his eyes wandered over the empty space ahead of him. Then he fell silent.

At the edge of his vision, he’d caught the Emperor smiling.

“…Ah.”

“Do you concede defeat?”

Baek Yeon realized the Emperor had been teasing him all along and sighed.

“I do.”

“That makes one victory for you and two for me.”

“Are you keeping score?”

“I was once a general like you. What matters more to a general than victory or defeat?”

At the sight of the Emperor laughing with evident delight, Baek Yeon couldn’t help joining in with a hearty laugh.

What else mattered? If the Emperor was happy, that was enough.

Three days ago, his face had been shadowed by approaching death. Now it shone as brightly as the full moon. That was what mattered to Baek Yeon.

And yet part of him felt bitter.

The Emperor looked as though he had already accepted, deep down, the death awaiting him. Baek Yeon could do nothing but look at him and laugh along.

I know why you sent No Shadow and me to His Highness.

It wasn't only to guard against some unforeseen danger and protect the Emperor's only brother and heir.

The Emperor was preparing for what would come after his death. Before it was too late, he was handing his loyal retainers and his power base over to Imperial Younger Brother Zhu Bao.

Yet in the past three days, he hadn't shown his face once to the brother he loved so dearly.

You don't want him to see you like this.

For brothers reunited after more than a decade, the coming death would not be a parting for the Emperor alone.

Zhu Bao, the Great Nation's new heir, would have to endure it too. Just when he had finally come to know the love and sincerity of family, he would have to let go of his only blood relative.

The Emperor must have known. He needed to tell his brother to prepare for their parting, but he was afraid to face the boy's grief. So he stayed away.

…I see.

Baek Yeon forced the corners of his mouth back up. Not wanting to spoil the Emperor's brief happiness, he spoke as brightly as he could.

"By the way, something good must have happened today. Did Jin Taekyung bring you some amusing news?"

"Amusing news? He did."

"I'd like to hear it."

"It's nothing much."

The Emperor smiled as he added the next words. Baek Yeon's smile vanished.

"He said he'd save me. One way or another."

"…!"

"It was amusing. He knows nothing about medicine, yet he made such a bold promise. But Baek Yeon, do you know what's even more amusing?"

The Emperor didn't wait for an answer.

"Those few absurd words made me feel hopeful."

It was strange. How could Jin Taekyung promise such a thing with such certainty on his face, such a gleam in his eyes?

The Emperor had enjoyed seeing him like that. He was grateful, too. That irreverent martial artist was determined to save a life the Emperor himself had given up on.

But the reality as the Emperor knew it remained cold.

It's probably impossible.

How cruel hope could be to someone facing a death already foretold.

He had folded that brief hope away and tucked it deep in his heart. For now, he simply wanted to speak to his loyal subject with a lighter heart.

“You look troubled. I’m fine, Baek Yeon. Don’t worry about me.”

“But if word of this gets out…”

The Emperor smiled at Baek Yeon’s worried look and waved a hand.

“He promised me he wouldn’t tell anyone else. Jin Taekyung is a man I can trust.”

“So…”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice was heavy when I finished telling him everything.

“The Emperor’s been poisoned with Blood Soul Gu?”

I nodded without hesitation.

“Yes.”

Promises are made to be broken.

Chapter 936

Jeok Cheongang's reaction to the truly grave news that the Emperor had been poisoned with Blood Soul Gu was short and to the point.

"That must hurt."

"…?"

"What? Am I wrong?"

"Well, no, but it's a little more serious than *hurting*."

Anyone listening would think the Emperor had a cold instead of Blood Soul Gu.

Jeok Cheongang shrugged at my baffled look.

"Same difference. He's in so much pain he's at death's door, isn't he? Even that needlessly tight-lipped quack can't cure him."

At the sudden jab, the Divine Physician—who'd looked uncomfortable throughout my account—spoke up.

"The patient told me not to inform anyone until he spoke of it himself. I merely respected his wishes. And why am I a quack?"

"If a physician can't cure an illness, he's a quack. Take that Divine Physician name tag off today."

"I never put one on. It wasn't mine to begin with."

"Since we're on the subject, let me ask you something. What if…"

"I know what you're thinking, but even if my master came, it wouldn't change anything."

I'd wanted to ask the same thing. The Divine Physician had answered a beat before I could, calmly and firmly.

"Blood Soul Gu… is unlike any of the deadly poisons known to us. It's almost as if it was created solely to kill its host."

Jeok Cheongang gave a low groan.

"You mean there's no antidote?"

"Poison and medicine come from much the same root. There must be a way to treat it. The problem is time."

He was right. The Emperor was dying even now.

Three days ago, just after the battle in the grand banquet hall, he'd looked unusually exhausted. I hadn't imagined it.

"From what I've seen, his vitality is already at its limit. I can't even guarantee he'll last another couple of months."

For the Divine Physician to say that meant the poison had advanced beyond anything elixirs or internal energy could hold back.

Like a jar full of holes that wouldn't fill no matter how much water you poured into it, the Emperor's life force was draining away fast.

At this rate, he'll die before long. If the Emperor dies suddenly, the Great Nation will be thrown into chaos.

Personal feelings aside, the Emperor couldn't die.

He'd borne every kind of disgrace and ruled the Great Nation for over ten years without any serious unrest.

And he'd held on to the throne despite the powerful opposition led by the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord. That alone showed what an exceptional ruler he was.

I have to save him. For what's coming, if nothing else.

I'd heard that outside the palace, things were already boiling like a cauldron over hot coals.

Two days before I woke up, the Emperor had carried out another large-scale purge, then posted hundreds of proclamations across the Imperial Capital.

The huge sheets, clearly stamped with the Imperial Seal, laid out the whole truth in detail.

They also carried the Emperor's declaration that he would crush the vile traitors known as Dark Heaven.

The war is about to begin.

No—it had already begun.

The Emperor's resolve was clear, and the people's anger toward Dark Heaven was spreading like wildfire.

To them, Dark Heaven was an outside enemy threatening their homes and their lives. No one wanted war, but they had to fight to protect the peace.

And this war needed someone to lead them all.

A powerful leader, cool-headed and thorough, with the authority to push through bold decisions when necessary.

Experience on many battlefields would make that leader all the better.

"What do you intend to do, Young Master Jin?"

I answered the Divine Physician's grave question calmly.

"We have to save him somehow."

"But we have no way to do that. As I said, there isn't enough time."

"That's all right. The method I'm going to try probably won't take long."

"You sound quite certain… Do you have a plan I don't know about?"

"I do. A brilliant one."

Jeok Cheongang, who'd been listening in silence, suddenly widened his eyes.

"Wait. This plan of yours…"

"It's what you're thinking."

"I'd forgotten all about it. Yes, that treasure changes everything."

Jeok Cheongang tapped his forehead. Only then did the Divine Physician blink in apparent surprise.

“Don’t tell me you have the Myriad-Poison Ring in mind?”

“Of course. What else?”

“Huh…”

At his low sigh, I gave a short laugh and continued.

“Even against Blood Soul Gu, the Myriad-Poison Ring gives us a good chance. No—it can definitely cure him.”

The ring had absorbed even the Formless Ultimate Poison that had once threatened Jeok Cheongang, and without much difficulty.

The Divine Physician had treated Jeok Cheongang alongside the Slaughter Saint back then. He knew better than anyone what the ring could do, so it was strange that he hadn’t thought of it until now.

“I guess you’ve had a lot on your mind, given the circumstances. I understand. It happens.”

“Y-Young Master Jin.”

“It’s fine. As you know, I left it with Prince Shangshan—or rather, the Imperial Younger Brother. I’ll go get it now. It’ll only take a moment, so you can prepare the treatment while I’m gone.”

“Young Master Jin?”

“Oh, come on. Anyone can forget something now and then. Why are you making such a big deal of it? I’ll be off, then.”

I gave him a friendly smile and turned.

Or I tried to—until I noticed what he was holding.

“…?”

Wait. What’s that?

I stared at the all-too-familiar ring for a moment before breaking the silence.

“That’s strange. It looks a lot like something I know.”

The Divine Physician gave me a flat look.

“It would.”

“I guess they make incredible knockoffs on this continent. Where’d you buy it?”

“I didn’t buy it.”

“Oh, someone gave it to you as a gift?”

“It wasn’t a gift, either. I borrowed it for a while.”

“From whom?”

“I explained the general situation to His Highness the Imperial Younger Brother. When I said I needed it for something important and had come on your behalf, he handed it over without asking for details.”

My vision swam.

I steadied my breathing and managed to ask, “And that important thing was…?”

“What else? I’ve been to Qianqing Palace twice today.”
“I didn’t hear anything about that from His Majesty…”
“Did he need to?”
“Then the result was…?”
“Just what I told you earlier.”
Silence fell again, heavier and more suffocating than before.
No one ventured to speak. Then Jeok Cheongang’s low voice rang out.
“That plan was so brilliant it plugged up your nose, too.”
“…”
“…”
Yeah.
What now?

SYSTEM

Quest
Dr. Choi Taekyung
You made a profound impression on the Emperor, who suffers from illness, by promising to treat him.
But for someone facing death, nothing is crueler than premature hope.
A man’s word is worth a thousand gold. Keep your promise.
Remove the Blood Soul Gu lodged in the Emperor’s head and free him from the pain that has tormented him for so many years.
If you fail to treat the Emperor…
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Successful treatment (Incomplete)
Reward: ???
Failure: ???

I stared at the empty air, then quietly closed the holographic window.
Only one thought filled my head.
I’m screwed.
Really screwed.
Who could’ve guessed even the Myriad-Poison Ring wouldn’t work?
No matter how much I pressed him, unable to accept it, the Divine Physician’s answer never changed.

"It failed."

"But it looked like it was going to work, right?"

"No. It failed."

"So it almost worked? Missed by a hair?"

"It failed completely. It simply doesn't work. In fact, the Blood Soul Gu sensed the ring's energy, felt threatened, and struggled even harder. I still break into a cold sweat thinking about it."

"Liar. Playing such a nasty prank on me, you little scamp."

"…Young Master Jin. Would you come over there and speak with me for a moment?"

Something had glinted inside the Divine Physician's sleeve. When I looked, I saw an acupuncture needle big enough to pierce the sole of an elephant's foot.

A chill ran down my spine, and I made my way back to my quarters as if fleeing. That had been barely fifteen minutes ago.

Damn it.

What had made me bold enough to promise the Emperor he'd be discharged safe and sound?

I'd put all my faith in that overpowered item, the Myriad-Poison Ring. It had dealt with the Formless Ultimate Poison easily enough. Surely it could kill one lousy bug.

And yet.

I'm screwed.

Yeah. Screwed.

Worse than screwed.

Forget the quest—the Emperor's death had to be prevented. But with my last hope, the Myriad-Poison Ring, gone, my vision had gone yellow.

"What the hell… am I supposed to do?"

I stared blankly at the ceiling I'd grown accustomed to, muttering to myself. Then Hyuk Mujin—who seemed to have claimed one corner of the room as his own—came over and patted my shoulder, as if this were only natural.

"It's all right, Captain. Everything's all right."

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Do you even know what the hell you're talking about?"

"I do."

Mujin nodded confidently.

"You got dumped by Young Lady Ju, didn't you?"

"…"

"Ah. Guess not. I'm sorry for overstepping."

When it came to apologizing, he was a Supreme Peak master.

He bowed at the speed of light, then looked wistfully at the pocket watch hanging from my neck.

“But seriously, what happened?”

“Mujin. When you’re talking to someone, look them in the eye. Not at their watch.”

“It gleams so beautifully that I couldn’t help myself.”

I badly wanted to whack him on the back of the head, but I didn’t have the energy.

I let out a long sigh and explained the situation in broad strokes, taking care not to reveal that the Emperor was the person at the center of the story.

“So someone promised to treat a seriously ill person.”

“Yeah.”

“But after making all those grand claims, they have no plan or way to do it.”

Every word hurt.

I flinched and added cautiously, “That’s true, but to be precise, they had a way. Then it was gone.”

“Either way, there’s no way to treat the person now, right?”

“Right.”

“Hmm. Got it.”

Mujin nodded and delivered his judgment in a stern voice.

“What a total piece of shit.”

“…!”

“Don’t you think so too, Captain? How could someone give that kind of hope to a person who’d only just made peace with dying? With nothing certain to back it up. I don’t know what kind of bastard would…”

He saw me trembling. His voice dropped at once.

“I think he’s a very handsome, dignified, upstanding young man who always gives others hope.”

“…”

“…”

“…Are you done?”

“…Should I say more?”

“…No.”

Stop. You’re making me feel worse, you bastard.

I gave him a sad look, silently telling him to stop, then lowered my head, unable to face Hyuk Mujin.

Tap-tap-tap.

Someone approached at a run. The door opened, and a familiar face appeared.

“I heard it was important, so I took care of it as quickly as I could… Oh my, why’s the mood so grim?”

It was Hong Jin.

Chapter 937

"I heard it was important, so I took care of it as quickly as I could… Oh my, why's the mood so grim?"

Hong Jin sensed the tension as soon as he entered the room. I answered with a troubled expression.

"It's nothing."

"Nothing? It sure looks like something happened."

Hong Jin glanced between Hyuk Mujin and me, then murmured, his expression suddenly serious.

"Oh, that's what it is? Hmm. But there's nothing you can do about that."

"…?"

"It's all right, so don't take it too hard. These things happen sometimes. It's part of life."

Could Hong Jin know, too?

He was now the East Depot eunuch, so it was entirely possible he knew about the Emperor's illness.

Maybe he'd heard something while enthusiastically torturing rebels for the last three days.

Having reached what seemed like a reasonable conclusion, I cautiously asked, "You already knew?"

Hong Jin hesitated for a moment, then nodded.

"Yeah. I happened to hear."

"It's supposed to be top secret… More people know than I expected."

"Eyes and ears are everywhere. No matter how tightly you try to keep something under wraps, word gets out eventually."

Fair enough. The Emperor keeping quiet couldn't protect every secret.

Every incident had victims and perpetrators, and perpetrators had mouths, too.

The rebels who were already dead—or waiting for death.

Some of those who'd passed through Hong Jin's and the Embroidered Uniform Guard's hands must have been close aides to the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, and known the Emperor had been poisoned with Blood Soul Gu.

"You must've found out while interrogating the prisoners. Which ones knew?"

"What?"

"The prisoners who knew about it. They must have been closely connected to the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord."

"Uh, well…"

Maybe it was a sensitive subject.

I realized my mistake too late and was about to wave it off when Hong Jin, who'd been blinking quietly, continued.

"I heard it from Taishan."

"Ah. I see… Wait. Who?"

"Taishan. That huge guy."

"…?"

No, something wasn't right here.

Hyuk Mujin spoke up in my place.

"You mean the Taishan I know?"

"Yeah."

"Built like a mountain, just like his name?"

"That's right."

"Usually an idiot, but smart whenever food comes up?"

"I don't know about that part."

"Obsessed with five-spice pork?"

"That part's definitely true. Actually, some intelligence came in yesterday. According to my men, the imperial cooks tried to poison his food."

If he was the imperial cooks' number one assassination target, then it had to be the Taishan I knew.

Utterly confused, I asked, "How would he know about that?"

"How else? He saw it."

"That can't be right. He couldn't have seen it."

"He said he saw it clearly."

"…What are you even talking about?"

"…That's what I'd like to ask you. What's all this about prisoners and interrogations?"

Hong Jin frowned at me, then went on.

"Weren't you talking about 'that thing' that happened right after Young Master Jin woke up?"

"W-what?"

"You look really unsettled. Is that why? I told you it's fine, so why are you still worrying? You just have a little more energy than other people."

"…!"

Oh, shit.

My vision went dark in an instant, and my whole body trembled.

"How… how did you know?"

"It's all over the palace. Didn't you know?"

"It's all over…?"

"I was away for a while, so I'm one of the last to hear. Less than two shichen[3431] after you woke up, half the people in the Inner Palace probably knew."

I couldn't breathe. My hands and feet shook, and I felt like I was about to cry.

It was like turning on the TV one day out of boredom and finding a national broadcast channel throwing a wet-dream party for me.

Twitching like I was sick, I barely managed to force the words out.

"Taishan. Bring that bastard here right now."

Hyuk Mujin, who'd frozen with his mouth hanging open, answered.

"I'm really sorry to say this, but Taishan's stronger than I am."

"Bring him here, no matter what!"

"Come on, Captain. You know he tears people apart with both hands."

"I can tear you apart with one."

"Ah. Aah."

Hyuk Mujin let out a brief yelp and dashed out. Sensing the mood turn heavy, Hong Jin spoke with a troubled expression.

"Young Master Jin. Don't take it so hard."

For the moment, even my worries about treating the Blood Soul Gu had been driven from my mind.

I groaned at his attempt to comfort me. "Easy for you to say when it's not happening to you."

"I told you it's fine."

"What's fine? Have you ever been in a situation like mine?"

At my sharp question, Hong Jin answered with a sad smile.

"Of course not. I had it cut off a long time ago."

"…"

"Just look on the bright side. I'm actually jealous of you, Young Master Jin. Especially during the rainy season, it aches so much down there that sometimes I can barely walk without poppy…"

"Okay, I get it. I get it, so please stop."

Using his eunuch trump card—one he pulled out whenever he was bored—to shut me up, Hong Jin held out something he'd been carrying and continued.

"I was going to do that anyway. I'm a busy man, too. I only came to hand over the item I was asked to deliver."

My badly backfired question had snapped me to my senses. Only then did I notice the small iron chest in Hong Jin's hand and remember why he'd come back.

The mysterious place the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had told me about in his final moments.

[3431] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

The item he'd said to find there.

This is…

"It's an iron chest, as you can see. I don't know what's inside or who left it there, though."

"You didn't open it?"

"Of course not. I promised you I wouldn't."

Hong Jin shrugged and added with a smile, "Besides, I wasn't sure I could open it."

He'd said it like a joke, but the moment I took the chest from him, I realized it wasn't entirely one.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Very Sturdy Iron Chest acquired.
New Item acquired. Would you like to appraise the Item and view its information?

I gave a slight nod, and a translucent holographic window opened between Hong Jin and me.

SYSTEM

Item Window
Very Sturdy Iron Chest
Grade: Peak
Restriction: None
Description: An iron chest made by mixing in a small amount of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. As you'd expect, it's incredibly durable—perfect for use as a shield or for storing precious belongings.
However, it has no fewer than five locks, so using it often may be a bit of a hassle.

I read the text quickly and swallowed a dry laugh.

Seriously? Even if it's only a little, why use Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron in an iron chest…?

Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron was incredibly rare—and filthy expensive to match.

If a reasonably well-known smith used even four nyang[3432] of it to forge a weapon, people would call it a fine sword. Use any more than that, and foul-tempered masters with a habit of spitting would descend on it like A-Gwi.

[3432] A nyang is a traditional Korean unit of weight of about 37.5 g (1.32 oz); four nyang are about 150 g (5.29 oz).

In short, it wasn't something you could easily get just because you had money. And no matter how rich you were, any sane person would use it to forge a weapon.

There weren't many people crazy and rich enough to mix Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron into an iron chest that was nothing more than a storage box.

Of course…

I can think of one right away.

I gave a bitter smile and ran my hand over the chest.

As if to prove it had been buried deep underground, its surface was damp, and patches of soil that hadn't been brushed off gave off a strong earthy smell.

What could it be? What did you want to hide so badly?

I was thinking of the chest's former owner, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, when Hong Jin rose to his feet with a wink.

"I'll get going. I'd only be in your way if I stayed."

He didn't wait for my answer before leaving the room. Before closing the door, he passed along one more message.

"Oh, His Highness the Imperial Younger Brother asked me to tell you something."

"What…?"

"He misses his one and only friend. He can't come see you right now because of the circumstances, but he wants to make sure he sees you before he leaves."

His one and only friend.

Remembering what he'd said when he gave me the Myriad-Poison Ring at Qianqing Palace, I couldn't help laughing softly.

"Tell him I feel the same way."

Hong Jin answered with a slight smile of his own, then left. Once I'd confirmed that all signs of life around me had disappeared, I set the iron chest on the floor and abruptly held out my hand.

Inventory open. Summon.

Ding.

With the brief command recited in my mind, familiar, cold metal settled into my grip.

White Flame.

My personal weapon, a divine weapon forged by the world's greatest smith after a year of arduous work.

And the key—the physical kind—to that tightly locked iron chest and its five padlocks.

"Let's see what you were so determined to keep hidden."

I murmured, then brought the spearhead down without hesitation.

Slice.

A flash of light, and the metal split apart.

The blade passed cleanly through all five padlocks in a single stroke. I looked inside the chest.

This is…

I'd known from the moment I first picked up the iron chest, but its contents were as spare as its weight was light.

A dozen or so bamboo slips, so old they were practically rotting away.

Alongside them lay bundles of relatively recent-looking paper, still white and clean, and a small silk pouch.

What is this?

The moment I saw them, an inexplicable shiver ran down my spine.

These were the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord's—or, to put it another way, what he'd left behind.

They had to be worth more than gold and more dangerous than gunpowder, in ways that couldn't be measured by their weight or shape alone.

It didn't take long for me to realize my instinct was right.

No—it took only moments.

Rustle.

The moment I untied the string around the bundle of papers on top, still pristine white, a bolt of lightning shot through the crown of my head.

"…!"

My entire body went rigid.

As I read the writing covering the pages, my eyes trembling, Hyuk Mujin's voice reached me. I hadn't heard him come back.

"Um, Captain. I don't think I can bring him…"

His voice echoed as if from far away.

I struggled to contain the turmoil inside me and spoke.

"…Bring them."

"What?"

"Bring everyone here. Now!"

"…!"

Hyuk Mujin's face went rigid. He'd sensed something was wrong.

Chapter 938

“Has it been about fifty years?”

Jeok Cheongang murmured as he looked out over the garden, filled with rare flowers and plants of every color.

“Back then, Mount Li in Shaanxi looked just like this. It was the height of spring, and everything was in bloom.”

This wasn’t merely an old man reminiscing aloud. He was speaking to someone seated against a moss-covered wall.

“Mount Small Hua.”

“Hmm?”

“It was Mount Small Hua, not Mount Li.”

Her voice was calm and clear.

Jeok Cheongang shook his head at the Bow Saint’s correction.

“That can’t be right. I remember soaking in hot spring water. Mount Li’s been famous for its hot springs since ancient times.”

“It wasn’t a hot spring. It was a small pond—until someone said he couldn’t stand cold water and heated it with Scorching Yang Qi.”

“Did he?”

“You’ve completely forgotten how the Thunderbolt Saber King flew into a rage and nearly started a fight.”

“That Peng bastard?”

The Bow Saint nodded. Jeok Cheongang frowned.

“I don’t remember it, but he was an idiot then and he’s an idiot now. All that fuss over a little warm water.”

“He had good reason. The Thunderbolt Saber King was already in the pond.”

“He’s a big fellow. I must’ve mistaken him for a bear.”

The Bow Saint gave a small sigh at his shameless reply.

“You haven’t changed.”

“People aren’t so different from those flowers. Wind and rain batter them day and night, and a sudden change in their surroundings can kill them. If you want to live even one day longer, you have to stay the same—like this old man.”

“So you came to tell me the secret to a long life?”

“Does this old man look like he has that much time on his hands?”

“You showed up out of nowhere and started telling stories I’d rather not remember. You don’t look that busy.”

Jeok Cheongang smiled bitterly at her dry reply.

This time, he couldn’t disagree. No matter how he looked at it, those weren’t happy memories.

They’d gathered there one spring more than fifty years ago—not simply to laugh and talk. He couldn’t even remember the exact year now.

“Three thousand members of the death squad climbed that mountain together. Before a day had passed, half of them had been buried there.”

Mount Small Hua, green beneath the bright spring sky, had become a mountain of fire, dyed red from end to end.

He could still see it clearly: flames surging up the mountainside, blood mingling with the water in the valleys, and more corpses than he could count strewn everywhere.

The Zhongnan Sect. The Huashan Sect. The Hebei Peng Family.

And alongside them, smaller orthodox factions whose names had faded from people’s memories long ago.

The Blade of Flowers, Jin Baekyang—then the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan—had been there too.

The three thousand elite members of the death squad surged like a wave toward ten thousand Demonic Cult followers led by five great fiends. They broke against them, scattering blood instead of white foam.

At dawn, when the survivors stood atop a mountain of Demonic Cult corpses and shouted in victory, two kings and one star stood at their center.

“One thousand three hundred and nineteen.”

“…!”

“That’s how many people died that day.”

Her quiet voice cut through the night air.

Jeok Cheongang stopped short, then slowly turned.

“You remember? All of them?”

Though his body had grown young again, the years remained in his eyes. And in those eyes, the woman’s gaze looked much like his own.

“I’ve never forgotten. Not for a moment.”

“…I didn’t know you were that kind of person.”

“Knowing changes nothing. All I do is remember them.”

The Bow Saint fell silent for a moment before adding, “That was simply the kind of time it was.”

Jeok Cheongang gave a faint nod.

“Yes. It was.”

The Demonic Cult’s momentum had been terrifying back then.

No—overwhelming.

The Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples swept in like a wave, crushing the Kunlun Sect as they crossed Qinghai. Then they split into three forces and advanced unchecked.

Toward Sichuan. Toward Gansu. And beyond Shaanxi, into the heart of the continent known as the Central Plains.

Not even the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families could stop that wave. The orthodox factions, still divided and guarding their own territories, crumbled almost at once.

The Demonic Cult's long-cherished dream of a world ruled by the Demonic Path no longer seemed far-fetched.

Until one man appeared.

"Do you know what I was thinking the day I came down from Mount Jiuhua, after killing every last bastard who'd dared set it on fire?"

Jeok Cheongang didn't wait for an answer.

"I swore to myself that until my dying breath, I'd kill as many Demonic Cult followers as I could."

With the war already turning against them, taking on the Demonic Cult alone was madness.

The kind of madness only Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, could attempt.

"But it turned out someone was even crazier than this old man."

Jeok Cheongang laughed. He remembered preparing to charge straight at the Demonic Cult forces that had occupied Anhui after driving out even the Namgung Family.

"I just couldn't believe it. Three thousand Demonic Cult followers defeated by one man."

Those three thousand weren't a rabble who'd barely risen above Third Rate. They were elites forged by the Demonic Cult's brutal training, fanatics who had sworn absolute loyalty to the Heavenly Demon.

Among them were two great fiends who had reached the Supreme Peak realm.

"Of course, eventually I had no choice but to believe it."

The story was too incredible to accept, so he'd caught several Demonic Cult followers as they fled and interrogated them. He confirmed that their two leading great fiends and nearly half their forces had vanished.

All because of someone no one could identify.

"That was when I remembered what my late Master used to say. The world is vast and there are many masters, so I must never stop striving."

Before long, though, he understood.

Jeok Cheongang wasn't lacking. That unknown man was exceptional.

No—beside him, anyone would have seemed ordinary.

"The Martial God."

No one knew where he came from, what his name was, or how old he might be. Hardly anyone even knew his face.

He could wield every kind of martial art at will, and the disguise technique was no exception.

Yet everyone believed in him and followed him.

That was the kind of person he was. The only lamp lighting a world sunk in darkness. The sun, alone in the sky.

But precisely because of that, they could only circle him, instinctively unable to draw near.

They feared that the wind from a cautious outstretched hand might snuff out their only light.

Afraid that one step closer to the sun would leave them burning in its heat.

"So the Martial God's identity remained a mystery to the very end. No—no one could even dare imagine it. Not even the Thousand-Faced Fox, who served him more closely than anyone."

But now Jeok Cheongang knew the secret the world had never learned. At last, he understood why that man could be called the Martial God.

"Was it divine strength? That incomprehensible power."

At his near-whisper, the Bow Saint slowly rose.

"Why? Are you planning to spread the word?"

"This old man's only just started living like a proper person again. I won't have people calling me senile."

Jeok Cheongang gave a quiet laugh.

"So that's why you kept talking when you knew I could hear you? Just because I'm that brat's Master?"

"I simply saw no reason to hide it."

The Bow Saint met his gaze.

"I saw you on the battlefield. A Master and Disciple willing to throw away their lives to save each other."

"…!"

"That was when I understood how much you trust each other. Hiding the truth would have been pointless."

Where nothing was hidden, there could be no secret.

The Bow Saint had seen the bond between Master and Disciple clearly. And as the unbelievable story unfolded, she sensed Jeok Cheongang's qi remain steady while he silently watched, confirming what she had understood.

"When did you realize your Disciple was different from everyone else?"

Jeok Cheongang answered calmly.

“From the beginning until now. Always.”

“I think you misunderstand. I mean, when did you learn the truth about that boy…?”

“Does it matter?”

Jeok Cheongang cut her off. Her reflection appeared in his eyes, now dark and solemn.

“Nothing changes. From the day I took that brat as my Disciple, we’ve shared everything and faced it together.”

At that moment, the Bow Saint frowned.

Not because she hadn’t gotten the answer she wanted, but because she felt the air around them slowly heating up.

Rumble.

The wind stopped. The air trembled.

And at the center of it all stood Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King.

“But…”

He slowly turned his head away from the garden. His eyes glowed red, flickering in the darkness like ghost fires.

“Did you put my Disciple in danger just to make that trivial confirmation?”

Jeok Cheongang had not forgotten the rage and despair that seized him when Jin Taekyung collapsed, spraying blood.

His Disciple might have grown strong enough to stand shoulder to shoulder with the Elders of great sects—perhaps even their Sect Leaders.

He might no longer be a rash young man like others his age, but someone with the stature to call himself a grandmaster.

Jin Taekyung was still his one and only Disciple.

Whoosh!

White hellfire spiraled upward.

Through the heat haze rising from its terrible warmth, the Bow Saint spoke calmly.

“Two thousand five hundred and sixty-two.”

Jeok Cheongang stopped in his tracks. He had been moving toward her, but he thought he knew what that unexpected number meant.

“That’s how many of our people died in the grand banquet hall three days ago.”

“You know the number well. But…”

His voice came out cold, utterly unlike the power blazing around him.

“If someone had stepped forward sooner, fewer than half of them would have died.”

“Yes. I’m sure you’re right.”

“What!”

Whoosh.

The flames around Jeok Cheongang burned hotter. The Bow Saint went on, unruffled.

“Even so, I had to see it with my own eyes. Whether that boy truly was the chosen one. What power he possessed, and what kind of person he was.”

“How dare you…!”

“After every battle, I counted the dead. It was one way I could remember them.”

“Shut your mouth!”

“But if ten times as many died as they did three days ago—one hundred times… No, more than a thousand times as many—could you still be angry as you are now?”

“…!”

“To you, it may have been a trivial test that put your precious Disciple in danger. To me, it wasn’t.”

The Bow Saint looked into Jeok Cheongang’s trembling eyes.

“I made that decision for far more people than that. Perhaps for everyone in this world.”

“That was also why that person—the Martial God—chose me.”

Her soft murmur drifted through the cold night air.

Step.

Far away in the darkness came the faint sound of someone approaching.

They turned at the same time. Hyuk Mujin was running toward them with all his might.

Chapter 939

That guy…

Jeok Cheongang recognized the familiar face hurrying toward them through the darkness and drew in the aura surging through his body.

Was it because the unexpected, unwelcome visitor was Hyuk Mujin?

No. Something about Mujin's appearance was wrong.

Huff, huff.

His legs kept moving as he struggled for breath. Who knew how far he'd run? Sweat beaded on his face, and he looked desperate.

…Something must have happened.

Hoping his sudden sense of foreboding was mistaken, Jeok Cheongang called to Mujin, who had lost his bearings for a moment in the dark.

"What are you dawdling for?"

"Ah! Great Hero Jeok!"

Mujin rushed over, then stopped short when he spotted the Bow Saint.

"Th-this junior of Murim, Hyuk Mujin…"

The Bow Saint cut off his introduction with a small wave of her hand.

"Save the formalities. Tell us why you're here."

"It's… Captain. I mean, my lord ordered me to bring the two of you to him at once."

"The two of us?"

"Yes. I searched everywhere and couldn't find either of you. When I asked my lord, he told me where to look…"

The Bow Saint's brow furrowed.

But it wasn't because a junior so far below her—Jin Taekyung, who was practically still a child—had dared to summon her as if he could order her around.

"He said he'd explain everything in person. Everyone else is already gathered."

At that, the Bow Saint clicked her tongue softly.

"Something more serious than I thought must have happened. Serious enough for him to summon you and me."

Jeok Cheongang nodded gravely.

Taekyung could be reckless, but within the bounds he observed, the brat was scrupulous about courtesy. If he had sent a subordinate to fetch even the Bow Saint, who was an outsider to him, Jeok Cheongang couldn't begin to guess how serious the matter was.

—Unfortunately, I think we'll have to end our conversation here.

The Bow Saint's Sound Transmission reached his ear. Jeok Cheongang studied her calm face with a heavy gaze. She didn't look the least bit disappointed.

—So it seems. For tonight.

He meant to continue the conversation another time. There were things he still hadn't said and questions he hadn't dared to ask. He had no intention of leaving it at this.

—I hope our next conversation will be more meaningful than this one.

Despite his pointed words, the Bow Saint remained composed.

—I'm sure it will be. Even if it isn't next time, we'll have plenty of chances.

—What do you mean by…

Jeok Cheongang faltered at the many possible meanings in her answer. He was just about to continue when—

Flap, flap.

The sound of powerful wings suddenly rang overhead.

Those are…

Jeok Cheongang looked up. The Bow Saint turned at the same moment, and Mujin followed their gazes.

Whoosh!

Dozens of birds crossed the distant night sky. They flew in separate groups, each bound in a different direction, moving with the precision of creatures thoroughly trained.

"Messenger eagles…!"

Jeok Cheongang spoke almost in a groan. A weight settled in his chest.

Sending out so many precious messenger eagles—not ordinary messenger pigeons—meant the Great Nation's imperial court was on the move.

Probably because of the news his Disciple had brought.

What could have happened?

At least one thing was certain: there was no time left to hesitate.

"Lead the way. Hurry."

The night was still far too deep for dawn. Yet unseen unrest was already sweeping through the Imperial Palace.

"What happened?"

Those were Jeok Cheongang's first words as he swept in like the wind. Instead of answering, I held out what was in my hand.

Swish.

His gaze darkened at the sight of several sheets of paper, still slick with oil.

"A missive?"

A veteran martial artist whose experience was second to none in the world, he had immediately recognized the papers. He took the stack from me and skimmed through it quickly.

Before even a few moments had passed, he looked up, his face as hard as stone.

“Is everything written here… true?”

If it had been half an hour ago, I might not even have heard Jeok Cheongang’s voice.

But I’d since explained the situation to the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and passed the gist of it to Hong Jin and Qianqing Palace. I managed to answer calmly, though my answer was far from definite.

“I don’t know.”

“What do you mean!”

“To be precise, none of it has been confirmed yet. But…”

I looked from Jeok Cheongang’s rigid face to the Bow Saint, who was now reading the missive, and then to the Fire Dragon Pavilion members gathered inside the hall.

“The information is highly credible.”

“On what grounds?”

The Bow Saint set down the missive. Her gaze was graver than I’d ever seen it.

“No, before that—who sent it?”

“I don’t know that, either. Only that it was someone fairly high up in Dark Heaven.”

“How could someone like that send it to you…”

Her voice trailed off. Then she gave a low murmur.

“It wasn’t sent to you.”

Exactly. Whoever had written this missive had intended to pass the information to someone else.

“Could it be…?”

Jeok Cheongang spoke under his breath. I nodded.

“That’s right. It was among the things the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord kept.”

“…!”

“…!”

Their eyes widened. Even the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, who had heard the broad outline before Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint arrived, couldn’t hide their agitation.

Anyone who had read even one of those missives would react that way. The four or five sheets, still slick with oil, held information on which tens of thousands of lives depended. Maybe hundreds of thousands.

And one of them lay at my feet.

Tap.

I picked up the sheet with trembling fingers. Four characters caught my eye at once.

Shanxi Annihilation Plan.

At some unknown point in the past, someone had written to the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord: before the Double Ninth Festival[3433], Dark Heaven's main force would cross the vast northern grasslands and invade Shanxi Province.

Crack.

I clenched my teeth, swallowed a groan, and closed my eyes.

If—if this information was true…

Just half a month.

That was all the time left until the Double Ninth Festival[3434].

All the time Shanxi Province had left. No—the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Peace and turmoil went hand in hand.

Even in times of peace, disturbances great and small broke out somewhere in the world. And even amid the chaos of war, someone enjoyed peace.

That hadn't changed when the long, fierce age of rival warlords ended and the Great Nation unified the land. It had always been true, was true now, and would remain true.

And nowhere in this vast world saw more constant strife than the northern grasslands.

A land of grass, earth, and horses. By day, birds rode the blue skies. By night, wild beasts huddled in the darkness and roamed in search of corpses.

Before the age of rival warlords, a nomadic people had conquered vast territories and called themselves rulers of the world. Their descendants still lived on those grasslands, in gers[3435] made of cloth and grass rather than splendid palaces or behind towering walls, alongside the horses that had been their constant companions since they first learned to walk.

Yet the glory their great ancestors had won was slowly fading from memory.

"Hmm. Not bad. No—excellent."

The man spoke with satisfaction and took another drink.

Like other nomads, he had shaved the crown of his head and braided his remaining hair into a long queue. His imposing build and the golden crown on his

[3433] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month in the traditional Chinese calendar.

[3434] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month in the traditional Chinese calendar.

[3435] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the Mongolian steppe.

forehead would have made him stand out above everyone else—if not for the man seated beside him in the place of honor.

“Temur, my brother. Have you forgotten that too much of anything can become poison?”

The other man had deep eyes and a lean build. He clicked his tongue softly at the hulking Temur. On his forehead sat another golden crown, this one engraved with two horses.

“You’re right, Chinggen. You always are.”

Temur nodded at Chinggen, who looked displeased, then grinned, baring yellow teeth.

“But remember one thing. Alcohol is medicine in itself. It can never be poison.”

“Oh, Temur.”

“Don’t be like that on a fine day. Have a drink with me, hmm?”

Chinggen shook his head. Temur jabbed him in the waist, raised his cup high, and called out, “What do you say, proud brothers of the grasslands?”

“Waaah!”

Hundreds of warriors cheered inside the vast ger[3436]. Temur roared with laughter.

“That’s more like it!”

He was happy. Two years ago, he had led fewer tribespeople than there were warriors in this ger[3437]. But look at him now.

He wore a golden crown. Instead of drinking mare’s-milk wine, made by milking horses and boiling the milk with his followers, he drank his fill of fine liquor brought from the distant Central Plains.

And all around him, the cheers poured in.

“Long live Khan Temur! Long live Khan Chinggen!”

“May you live to a ripe old age!”

Khan.

Ruler of the vast grasslands. King over tens of thousands of horses and warriors.

How good it sounded. The title that had once been only a dream was his now.

The two brothers, who had shared life and death, joy and sorrow since childhood, had brought peace and prosperity to the endlessly turbulent grasslands—and at last earned the title of Khan.

“Can you hear them? Hm? I said, are you listening?”

Temur, who had been mingling with his warriors, filled Chinggen’s empty cup.

It was silver, imported from the Central Plains rather than carved from wood or animal bone. Its gleaming surface reflected both their faces: Temur’s broad grin and Chinggen’s unmistakable discomfort.

[3436] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the Mongolian steppe.

[3437] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the Mongolian steppe.

“Of course I hear them. But this isn’t the time to laugh and drink, Temur.”

“Good grief, there you go again. Since when does laughing and drinking need a special occasion?”

“My brother, didn’t I send a messenger with news?”

“Ah, that? I heard.”

Temur chewed noisily on a piece of meat as he continued.

“But don’t worry so much. We may be Khans now, but the grasslands are vast. We can’t do anything about what happens beyond our reach.”

Of course Temur knew. A few scouts had gone missing from time to time, and there had been several disturbances on the westernmost grasslands.

Not enough to make him forget the indulgence of the moment.

“Come, my ever-worried brother. Let’s empty our cups first, then talk.”

Temur laughed heartily and was about to offer Chinggen another drink when—

Flap.

A cold wind laden with sandy dust pushed open the entrance to the ger[3438].

[3438] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the Mongolian steppe.

Chapter 940

While a ger[3439] on the grasslands shivered in the cool night wind, heavy with sand, people behind a massive wall ten thousand li[3440] away were greeting the morning.

The sun was still a long way from rising. Darkness surrounded them on every side.

Thudthudthudthud!

Rough hoofbeats shattered the silence of the night.

More than a hundred messengers passed through the Seven Gates without a single formality. Like the dozens of messenger eagles sent ahead of them, they vanished into the wind, each bound for a different destination.

The man who had given all these orders listened, pale-faced, as reports came in one after another.

“All the messengers have just passed through the Seven Gates!”

“The Imperial Decree has been delivered to the high ministers of the Six Ministries!”

“The Censorate awaits Your Majesty’s command!”

“The officials of the Hanlin Academy and the Transmission Office are preparing the edict!”

“A report from the Five Tiger Commandery! In accordance with Your Majesty’s command, we are immediately mobilizing three hundred warships, one hundred thousand naval troops, and the Imperial Guards—”

“Enough.”

At the Emperor’s sudden command, every sound around him vanished as if washed away.

The Son of Heaven’s authority was absolute.

Though the Great Nation was only in its third generation, the power wielded by its current Emperor equaled—or perhaps surpassed—that of Taizu, who had unified the realm.

“How noisy.”

At the Emperor’s quiet murmur, everyone prostrated themselves, barely daring to breathe.

“We beg Your Majesty’s forgiveness!”

“Please execute us!”

Rustle.

The Emperor gave a small shake of his head and silently waved his long sleeve.

[3439] A *ger* is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the Central Asian grasslands.

[3440] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is 500 m (about 0.311 mi). Ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

Those who understood the unspoken command backed away and disappeared with careful steps. Before long, only two people remained in the vast main hall.

“Every time I say anything, they start begging me to kill them. If I’d had to listen to that for another fifteen minutes, I might’ve bitten through my own tongue.”

At the Emperor’s bitter smile, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, spoke with a stern expression.

“Even as a joke, please don’t say such things.”

“It’s only a joke. What does it matter? Besides…”

The Emperor leaned at an angle against the throne and continued.

“I have not the slightest intention of dying in a situation like this.”

His face was still pale, but as he faced a new crisis, his eyes gleamed like luminous pearls.

“I expected as much, but it’s worse than I thought. I didn’t think they’d move so quickly.”

Baek Yeon wholeheartedly agreed.

Dark Heaven.

That rebellious faction, whose very name was ominous, was larger than expected —and more methodical, too.

Even more so than a religious movement that had once erupted like a grass fire from a distant western land, back when Baek Yeon had served the late Emperor.

“It was more than fifty years ago that those called the Demonic Cult headed for the Central Plains.”

“The Great Faction War.”

The Emperor murmured to himself and stroked his graying beard.

Though it had happened long before he was born, everyone knew of the momentous event when no fewer than a hundred thousand cultists set foot in the Central Plains.

Especially because they weren’t merely country bumpkins lured in by sweet words. They were an army armed with unwavering faith and spears and swords.

“When the Demonic Cult’s momentum reached the heavens, the martial artists of the orthodox factions petitioned the late Emperor. They said the Demonic Cult was a foreign enemy disrupting the Great Nation’s order, and asked him to raise the Imperial Army and order a campaign against them.”

“I know.”

The Emperor looked at Baek Yeon and added,

“And I know you opposed joining the war more strongly than anyone.”

Baek Yeon gave a small nod in acknowledgment.

It was true.

Here, in this very place, the high ministers of the court had argued fiercely for days. The late Emperor had seriously considered ordering a campaign, but Baek Yeon had pleaded with him more earnestly than ever before, and the Emperor had finally given up the idea.

“Can Your Majesty guess why I opposed it so strongly?”

“I think there were two main reasons. First, the Demonic Cult feared the Great Nation’s power and wasn’t harming the people. And second… Cang Gong.”

“That’s right. Unlike me, Cang Gong was the first to insist that we drive out the foreign enemy.”

“You made the right choice. If Father had sided with Cang Gong back then, the Great Nation would have shed a great deal of blood.”

“It was clear he intended to weaken the imperial house. That was all the more reason I had to oppose it.”

There had never been a victory without wounds, not in all of history.

Baek Yeon knew that as a commander who led an army, not merely as a martial artist. He had done everything in his power to keep the Great Nation out of the war.

Cang Gong—or rather, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord—had already been someone to watch back then.

Of course, countless orthodox martial artists had died because of Baek Yeon’s opposition. But he didn’t regret it in the least.

He had simply made the choice that was best for the Emperor and the Great Nation—and, by extension, the people.

It wouldn’t have been too late to intervene after watching the two great powers, the Murim Alliance and the Demonic Cult, crash violently into each other.

And the result of that wait had been an orthodox victory that came close to mutual destruction.

“Back then, I actually hoped the Demonic Cult would win.”

The Emperor clicked his tongue at Baek Yeon’s words.

“You’re unusually honest today.”

“It can’t be helped. Many martial artists of the orthodox factions have the people’s trust, so we’d have no grounds to launch a campaign against them. But it would’ve been different if the Demonic Cult had survived.”

A massive boulder was too heavy even to move.

But what about a pebble left behind after being smashed and battered again and again?

And if that pebble had jagged edges sharp enough to harm the people, Baek Yeon would have taken up his hammer without the slightest hesitation.

He would have torn down the lawless fence that was Murim once and for all.

“But if things had gone as you hoped, we wouldn’t have made it to the present day.”

The Emperor’s low voice echoed through the vast hall.

He was right. It was deeply ironic, but they had relied on those very martial artists to put down the traitors and accomplish their great undertaking.

And now… it was time to set that contradiction right.

“I intend to help with everything I have. For their sake—and for all of us.”

Thump.

Baek Yeon lowered his head and went down on one knee.

A storm of bloodshed would soon descend, one that would dwarf the Great Faction War.

Dark Heaven was more powerful than the Demonic Cult, and incomparably more dangerous.

A war was beginning that would not be confined to Murim. It would overturn the world.

“Your Majesty, ruler of all beneath the heavens, I humbly ask that you give me your orders.”

The information Jin Taekyung had delivered in the dead of night was an unexpected misfortune. Fortunately, they had already made thorough preparations to accomplish their great undertaking.

Hundreds of warships and thousands of officers.

Hundreds of thousands of troops, the imperial banners flying above them, were waiting for their command.

“I command Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.”

Speaking in a solemn voice, the Emperor slowly rose despite his ailing body.

Instead of his white sleeping robe embroidered with a golden dragon, he wore heavy armor. He strode across the hall without hesitation.

Clank. Clank.

One step. Then another.

The Emperor descended from the throne and personally raised Baek Yeon to his feet.

“Tell the entire army that I will lead the campaign in person.”

“…!”

Baek Yeon’s eyes trembled for an instant, unable to hide his shock.

It wasn’t only the impact of the Emperor taking command in person. He could feel the resolve of a man who had little time left to live.

“Your Majesty.”

But the words Baek Yeon struggled to force out never came.

Seeing the Emperor silently shake his head, the loyal subject could only clench his teeth, his heart heavy.

"I, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard… will obey Your Majesty's solemn command."

The Emperor gave him a faint smile instead of an answer, then walked past him.

The world beyond the wide-open iron gates was still shrouded in darkness.

Like his own future, with so little of it left.

Still, this isn't so bad.

His body might be dying, but his mind was clearer than ever.

The first campaign he would lead in person—and the last.

To meet his end on a battlefield instead of in bed would be a blessing, not a tragedy.

And so was the fact that someone had brought back his will to live, if only for a while.

"Come, Baek Yeon."

The Emperor smiled brightly—so brightly it was hard to believe he was a dying man—and continued,

"We should see off a certain insolent rogue who's leaving before me without keeping his promise to me."

One shichen.[3441]

That was how much time had passed since I'd first gotten my hands on the iron chest left behind by the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

"Everything's ready."

At Hyuk Mujin's report in my ear, I opened my eyes, which I'd kept tightly shut.

His gaze and expression were unusually grave. That alone said how urgent things had become.

"Let's go."

What else was there to say?

I gave a brief reply and stepped out of the pavilion, moving as if in a daze.

Even after circulating my qi once, my mind was still a mess.

Half a month.

Only half a month.

That was all the time left until the Double Ninth Festival.[3442] Or maybe even less.

[3441] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours.

[3442] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

The missive the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord had kept said Dark Heaven's main force would invade Shanxi Province through the northern grasslands before the festival.

It could be ten days. No—even tomorrow.

I swallowed the groan rising in my throat.

This wasn't just urgent. It was an emergency.

The distance from here, Zhejiang Province, where the Imperial Capital stood, to Shanxi Province was a full ten thousand li.[3443]

No matter how quickly the Imperial Court's messenger eagles flew, the trip would take at least ten days.

Can I get there in time?

Even as I left the imperial palace with everyone else, doubt weighed heavily on my heart.

Then Jeok Cheongang, who had been watching me in silence the whole time, suddenly spoke.

"Was it about fifty years ago? I got into some petty dispute with that Thunderbolt Saber King bastard and ended up in a real fight."

As though he were talking to himself, Jeok Cheongang glanced away from me and continued.

"I'd always looked down on him as someone far beneath me, so I didn't think much of him. But when we actually traded blows, he was pretty strong. I didn't show it, but I was surprised."

The Bow Saint, who had been riding quietly with the reins in hand, replied.

"He's a strong man. If it hadn't been for you, he probably would've been the greatest of the Ten Kings."

"Hmm. I suppose so."

Jeok Cheongang nodded, then glanced at me and added,

"Still, the Hebei Peng Family didn't become one of the Five Great Families for no reason. With that kind of strength, they could beat just about anyone. And they have enough intelligence-gathering power to keep a clear eye on what's happening not only in Hebei but in Shanxi, too."

Only then did I think I understood.

This completely random conversation was meant to put me at ease.

Heh.

What was I supposed to say? I was just grateful.

And just as I swallowed the laugh threatening to slip out, someone spoke.

"So, were you planning to leave just like this without saying goodbye?"

[3443] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is 500 m (about 0.311 mi). Ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

The breezy voice didn’t suit him at all. The Emperor, who had been waiting for me in front of the enormous iron gates, laughed aloud.

Chapter 941

An endless stretch of city wall. A massive iron gate controlling passage to the north.

And at the head of a thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards and several court ministers standing in formation on either side, imperial banners embroidered with dragons held high, stood one man.

“So, were you planning to leave just like this without saying goodbye?”

The Emperor’s sudden appearance caught me off guard. Then I returned his smile with a faint one of my own.

“Your Majesty.”

“I hope I’m not taking up your precious time.”

“My time is precious, but I can spare a little of it for a meeting worth having. As it happens, there’s something I need to tell you in person, too.”

The Emperor tilted his head, not quite grasping what I meant, then smacked his lips.

“You sound as if you knew I’d be waiting.”

“Honestly, I didn’t expect that. But I’m glad to see you, even like this.”

“Enough of that empty flattery. It doesn’t suit you.”

The Emperor feigned a frown, then jerked his chin over his shoulder.

“Why not answer honestly, like you usually do? It isn’t me you’re glad to see. It’s them.”

He was right.

The Emperor wasn’t the only one waiting for me in front of the Imperial Capital’s North Gate.

That’s…

Familiar faces came into view.

The Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, Jeong Hogun—the first face I’d seen at the imperial court, and the one I’d seen most often since—was only the beginning.

Baek Yeon and Hong Jin, who should have been busier than anyone else right now, were there too. And I spotted someone I hadn’t seen in days.

Prince Shangshan. No—the Imperial Younger Brother.

Warmth spread through a corner of my heart. That boy, whose life had once hung by a thread, was now with his only family.

And I’d get to say goodbye before I left.

I gave Zhu Bao, who sat in his saddle looking ready to burst into tears, a faint smile. Then I turned back to the Emperor.

“May I answer honestly, as you said?”

“No, never mind. I’ve changed my mind.”

“I’ve changed mine too. You’re right—I’m happier to see them than I am to see Your Majesty.”

“How dare you…!”

His suppressed voice was accompanied by an air that instantly turned cold.

But after glaring at me for a moment, the Emperor burst into the laughter he’d been holding back.

“You never cease to amaze me. No—it’s downright bizarre. How can you be so arrogant and rude to the father of all the people and the supreme ruler?”

“As I’ve already told you, I’m just a rogue. I don’t even have an identity plaque, and I have parents of my own.”

Gasps sounded here and there.

Most of the people—especially the court ministers who had no idea why they were even here—looked at one another as if to ask whether this was really happening.

The Emperor, of course, was still smiling.

“I see. You are neither my subject nor a citizen of the Great Nation.”

Without waiting for my reply, he continued.

“But you think and act according to justice, righteousness, and chivalry. You are truly a hero of your age, worthy of the admiration of all.”

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

The Emperor rode slowly toward me until he was right in front of me. He gazed at me for a moment, then suddenly raised a hand to his shoulder.

Slip. Thump.

The tightly tied cord came loose. Without hesitation, the Emperor removed his cloak and held it out to me with a faint smile.

“What are you waiting for? Take it.”

“…!”

“…!”

An unseen shockwave swept through everyone.

The court ministers trembled as if they’d suffered strokes, staring aghast at the cloak embroidered with a golden dragon that looked ready to come alive.

“Y-Your Majesty!”

“T-That is…!”

Shouts came from every direction.

But their desperate voices were swallowed by the wind at the Emperor’s curt command.

“Enough.”

In the heavy silence pressing down on those around us, the Emperor turned his gaze to me and spoke.

"Go on. It's just a little gift from me."

I looked from the Emperor, who was urging me on, to the cloak in his hand. All I could do was blink.

Even without everyone's reaction, I knew this was no ordinary gift.

"This is… a lot more than a little gift."

It was no ordinary cloak.

The Emperor himself had worn it. That alone would have made it extraordinary. But something else mattered even more.

A dragon.

A single dragon embroidered on the cloak in golden thread.

Even a three-year-old knew it was the emblem of the Son of Heaven and the imperial house's authority.

"You seem to know what it means."

I answered in disbelief.

"How could I not?"

"Good. Then you'll be all the more eager to accept this precious gift before my hand falls off."

"Wait, wait a moment."

The sudden turn of events had me hesitating, but the Emperor was firm.

"Please don't refuse. If you do, something will happen that you'll deeply regret."

"What?"

I stared at him blankly. The Emperor continued in a deliberately stern voice.

"If you refuse even this, I'll be very hurt."

"What does that—"

"No one can say what might happen. But rest assured. Surely I wouldn't make the imperial house's Benefactor uncomfortable over something so trivial?"

"Is it just me, or was none of that reassuring?"

"Exactly. It's just you."

The Emperor and I stared at each other in silence for a while.

Then, as if we'd agreed to it, we both let out a dry chuckle.

We hadn't known each other long, but we already understood.

Maybe, just a little…

We were alike.

I had fought to protect what was precious to me. He, too, had made sacrifices for someone else.

He'd wagered his life without hesitation, and he didn't regret it.

The only difference was where we stood and what we saw. Just like me, the Emperor was only human.

Someone who knew how to be grateful for help, who liked jokes, who feared death.

One person who had fought as best he could from the place where he stood.

Swish.

I reached out, took the cloak the Emperor offered, and draped it over my shoulders. Then I respectfully clasped my hands in a salute.

"I gratefully accept this precious gift."

"It suits you. But there's one thing missing."

The Emperor looked at me in the cloak with satisfaction, then took a gleaming silver plaque from between the plates of his armor and held it out.

The next words made me doubt my ears.

"By the authority of the Son of Heaven, I name Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan Marquis of Shangshan!"

His voice, strengthened with internal energy, broke the deep-night silence.

As his declaration rang out, commoners who had watched the imperial procession from afar, not daring to approach, began gathering around the torches held by the Embroidered Uniform Guards.

The Emperor continued in a solemn voice.

"I grant you as your fief more than ten counties in Shanxi Province, including Taiyuan, Honju, Yangcheon, Jeongyang, Jinzhong, Taigu, and Jiaocheng, along with the revenues of ten thousand households and a hundred thousand taels[3444] of gold and silver. In addition…"

Shing.

A flash of light suddenly leapt from his waist. The Emperor drew the imperial sword, his eyes gleaming as he shouted,

"From this moment, I also grant you the post of Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard. Lead a thousand guards and, by imperial command, swiftly put down the foreign bandits who disturb the order of the realm!"

"…!"

"…!"

I could hardly breathe. My chest thudded.

Thump. Thump. Thump!

That wasn't my heartbeat.

The thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards standing in formation on either side stamped their feet with all their might. They clashed their weapons together and struck their armor.

For the Emperor.

No—for me.

[3444] A tael is a traditional unit of weight used for precious metals; its weight varied by place and period.

Ah.

I swallowed the groan rising in my throat.

Only now did I understand.

The Emperor hadn't brought a thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards here to wait for me merely as an escort.

They were a force assembled by imperial command to punish the enemy.

And they were reinforcements he'd prepared for me.

A shield and a sword to defend Shanxi Province and the Jin Family of Taiyuan against Dark Heaven.

"Waaaah!"

Ding. Ding-ding.

My ears rang with the ceaseless chiming of bells and the shouts and cheers erupting all around me.

And there, at the center of it all, the Emperor smiled at me.

"Success makes you a king; failure makes you a traitor."

Two had plotted a revolution, but only one had survived.

The Emperor had uprooted the traitors and put everything back in its place. Now he was rewarding those about to depart.

"Every deed has its due. What do you think of the gift I prepared?"

What more could I say?

I let out the breath I'd been holding.

"It's incredible."

"As a marquis, you should rightfully be my subject, but I don't care about that."

Tap.

The Emperor's hand came to rest on my shoulder. The spark of life within him was slowly going out, yet I could feel the warmth of his fingertips.

"Go on as you have until now."

"Keep your eyes on what is right. Let your intentions and actions follow righteousness and chivalry."

His voice flowed on, and he added quietly,

"Be neither my subject nor my citizen… Just be someone who shines a light upon this world."

His words, low and heavy, rang in my ears like a final testament.

Meeting and parting are inseparable.

Where there's a meeting, there's a parting; and after a parting, another meeting awaits.

Even so, the moment of parting is always bitter and full of regret.

Especially for a child saying goodbye to someone he had relied on so deeply.

Tap. Drip.

Moisture fell onto the saddle.

Rather than look at his youngest brother's silently weeping face, the Emperor gazed at the empty places left by those who had departed and spoke calmly.

"Are you that sad?"

"N-no, I'm not."

Zhu Bao hurriedly wiped his eyes with his sleeve.

A child was allowed to cry, but the Imperial Younger Brother was different.

As heir to the Great Nation, Zhu Bao would have to face the coming war. He had become someone who must never cry.

"I'm not sad at all."

"That's very strange."

"Pardon?"

"I'm sorry to see them go. How can you, not even fifteen yet, feel no sadness?"

Zhu Bao looked up in surprise. The Emperor's smiling face was reflected clearly in his eyes.

"Bao'er."

Zhu Bao stared at him, too stunned to answer. The Emperor spoke gently.

"You needn't start swallowing your feelings already."

"…!"

"They say endurance is bitter and its fruit sweet. But endurance that piles up like that will turn to poison one day."

"H-hyung.[3445] I mean, Your Majesty."

"When you want to cry, cry as much as you like."

Tap.

With an awkward hand, the Emperor stroked Zhu Bao's head. Then he turned his horse around and rode away.

He repeated something someone had once told him.

"You and I are both human, in the end."

As sobs rose behind him, the Emperor hoped that Zhu Bao—his youngest brother, at least—would not follow in his footsteps.

I… realized far too late.

A faint smile touched the Emperor's lips. Just then, a fine horse came galloping through the enormous iron gate as it slowly closed.

[3445] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger male uses to address an older brother or an older male he is close to.

Wait. That man…

Amid a situation he couldn’t understand, the Emperor saw the man who had returned and asked,

“Did you leave something behind, Divine Physician?”

“Yes.”

The Divine Physician smiled and continued,

“I left a patient behind.”

Chapter 942

“I left a patient behind.”

At the Divine Physician’s answer, the Emperor’s eyes trembled.

Could it be…?

Suddenly, he found it hard to breathe. Without realizing it, he clenched both fists.

A spark of hope kindled in a heart he’d thought he’d emptied completely. He could feel his resolve wavering—the resolve to die on a battlefield, not in his bedchamber.

No. It can’t be.

But deep down, the Emperor could only shake his head. A crisis could drive a person to the edge of a cliff. Hope was what finally sent them plunging into the abyss.

And so he forced himself to look away from the Divine Physician, who still watched him with a gentle smile.

“If you intend to join the army, I won’t stop you. Before long, there will be countless casualties. Your medical skills will be put to good use.”

“Your Majesty.”

Leaving the Divine Physician to finish whatever he’d meant to say, the Emperor quietly turned away.

Jin Taekyung, who had left to protect the Jin Family of Taiyuan, wasn’t the only one with no time to spare.

The Emperor’s life was truly drawing to a close. In the brief time he had left—a few months at most—he meant to do everything he could.

For a better future.

For the precious people who would remain in this world after he was gone.

That is my sole duty.

The moment he steeled his resolve again, a quiet voice sounded behind him.

“I understand, Your Majesty. I know how you feel.”

Thud.

The Emperor stopped as if his feet had been nailed to the ground.

The Divine Physician’s voice continued in his ear.

“A fleeting hope must frighten you. Nothing is more painful than false hope.”

After a brief silence, the Emperor slowly turned. The Divine Physician was still smiling at him.

“You understand well.”

“Through no choice of my own.”

“You must have met countless people standing between life and death in your work as a physician.”

“That’s not the only reason.”

“Then what is?”

The Divine Physician’s smile faded.

“A very long time ago, there was a young carpenter.”

“A carpenter? Did he come to you because he had a fatal illness, too?”

“More precisely, he came to save his wife and children from an epidemic.”

“…His wife and children.”

“He carried his feverish wife and two children on his back in a wooden carrying frame. For three days and nights, he climbed the mountain without sleep, looking for a skilled physician said to be staying in a nearby slash-and-burn farming village.”

The Emperor pictured the carpenter, drenched in sweat as he climbed the mountain, and muttered,

“That must have been hard. Very hard.”

“As you say, it surely was.”

“But I doubt he even felt how exhausted he was. He had hope he could save his family.”

The Divine Physician nodded.

“Yes. He didn’t set down the frame and collapse until he reached his destination. Then he lay sick for a day and a half.”

“So, did you treat his family?”

“Unfortunately, I couldn’t.”

The Emperor gave a small sigh. The Divine Physician added bitterly,

“By the time I regained consciousness, it was too late.”

“…!”

“That’s why I know how cruel hope can be. What kind of despair waits at the bottom of that cliff.”

The Emperor fell silent.

He looked at the old physician before him, seeing the young carpenter who had lost his wife and children to an epidemic long ago and chosen a new path. After a long while, he spoke.

“Then… then have you truly…?”

His voice shook with emotion he could not hide. He forced out the question he’d wanted to ask from the start.

“Have you found a way to treat Us?”

Light returned to his eyes, and hope crept into his voice.

The Divine Physician bowed deeply.

“Yes. With the help of Heaven—or rather, Young Master Jin—I was able to find the one and only path to survival.”

“…!”

Jin Taekyung.

The unexpected name made the Emperor close his eyes. In the darkness, he pictured Jin Taekyung’s face and offered him thanks he would never hear.

You didn’t forget your promise to Us.

He had not resented Jin Taekyung for leaving. Even when he’d watched him walk away without a word about their promise, he’d felt only gratitude for all Jin Taekyung had done for the imperial house.

He’d believed that was his duty—as ruler of this nation, as an older brother, and as a human being.

But Jin Taekyung had kept his promise after all. He had given the finest physician beneath Heaven a hope brighter than ever before and sent him back.

What more can I do for him to repay this debt?

It didn’t matter. Whatever Jin Taekyung wanted, the Emperor would gladly give him.

With a quiet chuckle, the Emperor opened his eyes and slowly spoke.

“Tell Us. What must We do to live?”

For some reason, the Divine Physician’s smile turned awkward.

“What is it?”

“Well, you see… That is…”

“There’s no need to hesitate. We’ll trust your word and follow your instructions without the slightest doubt.”

“Forgive me, but even so, there may be a slight misunderstanding…”

The Emperor thought he knew what made the Divine Physician hesitate.

It happened all the time. He was the Emperor, ruler of all beneath Heaven. If anything went wrong with his health, the imperial physicians might have to answer for it with their lives. Even the finest physician beneath Heaven would worry about the consequences.

“Whatever concerns you, We assure you that nothing of the sort will happen. We swear by Our name… No, We swear upon the tombs of the late Emperors.”

The Divine Physician had been silently working his lips for some time. At the Emperor’s gentle reassurance, he finally spoke.

“Are those words truly sincere? Without the slightest falsehood?”

“Of course. From this moment on, We are a patient in need of your treatment before We are the Son of Heaven. We’ll trust you and follow your instructions, whatever they may be.”

“Very well. Since Your Majesty has said as much, I’ll speak frankly.”

In the next instant, the Emperor understood why the Divine Physician had hesitated—and how much he'd understated matters with *a slight misunderstanding*.

"The truth is, there's no way to save Your Majesty."

"…?"

"To treat you, you must first die once. That's where it begins—Your Majesty?"

The Emperor blinked. Somehow, his treasured sword was in his hand.

"Now, why would this suddenly—"

"Your Majesty? Your Majesty!"

"I'm sorry, Divine Physician. But We didn't draw it of Our own will. The sword is moving by itself."

"Your Majesty!"

The Emperor approached with his sword, offering an excuse even a passing traitor wouldn't believe. The Divine Physician let out a shrill scream.

At the same time, he held out the thing he'd taken out earlier, just in case—the thing Jin Taekyung had given him a few shichen[3446] ago.

Or rather, he threw it at the Emperor.

Clack.

The Emperor reached out on instinct and caught it.

Rattle!

The cord binding it came loose, and bamboo slips unfurled, so old they had half rotted away.

"…What is this?"

His puzzlement lasted only a moment. As he made out the faint characters that remained, his eyes widened.

Maoshan Sect.

White Illusion Jiangshi Art.

It was the ancient root of a sect belonging to someone who no longer existed in this world, and who had treasured it dearly.

Dududududu!

The thunder of hooves rang out through the darkness.

The fine horses, said to carry the blood of sweat-blood horses, lived up to their reputation. Not one stopped for even a moment, and none of us—including me—slackened our reins.

"Deokcheong County is just beyond that hill!"

[3446] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

Ju Hwaran's shout cut through the wind rushing past us.

We'd reached a second county just one shichen[3447] after leaving the Imperial Capital. It was good news, but I couldn't smile.

Not yet. At this speed, I can't even be sure we'll reach Anhui Province by noon.

Neither our speed nor our time was nearly enough.

Even the imperial messenger eagles and couriers, who had left the capital about half a shichen[3448] ahead of us, might not arrive before the fighting began.

We had to hurry.

"Jeong Hogun!"

At my call, carried by internal energy, Jeong Hogun rode forward, his helmet pulled low.

"Speak."

"How much longer until we reach Shanxi Province?"

Jeong Hogun thought for a moment as his horse raced onward.

"Ten days at the least. Fifteen at most."

A difference of five whole days. And I knew fifteen wasn't some leisurely estimate.

"Be more specific."

"Fifteen days if we change horses on time at counties with relay stations ready and take only the bare minimum of rest."

"Damn it. And ten days?"

"That means taking the shortest possible route in a straight line. We'll have to cross rugged mountains and rivers. Depending on the terrain, we may have to abandon our horses…"

Jeong Hogun trailed off. He glanced at the thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards racing ahead as one with their horses, then at the Fire Dragon Pavilion members following them.

"And we can forget about rest."

His expression and tone were as impassive as ever, but I could hear the concern beneath them.

No, I couldn't miss it, either.

Reaching Shanxi Province won't mean it's over.

We didn't know exactly when Dark Heaven would invade. If Heaven was on our side, we'd arrive before the fighting began and have time to rest. But there was every chance we wouldn't.

If Dark Heaven has already taken Shanxi, or we arrive just as the battle begins…

No need to finish that thought.

I spat out the curse that had been on the tip of my tongue for a while.

[3447] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

[3448] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours.

“Goddamn it.”

Shhk!

Jeong Hogun cut off a branch hanging over the road, spat out a leaf that had landed in his mouth, and replied,

“I understand how you feel, but I doubt you called me over just to say that.”

His tone was so cold it made me dislike him on the spot. I felt my overheated thoughts cool down.

“Shit. This sucks.”

“Good. Are you done feeling sorry for yourself?”

“You cold bastard.”

“…”

“You can’t even show a little sympathy. No wonder you don’t have a single friend.”

“…That doesn’t sound like feeling sorry for yourself.”

“Of course it does. Just me feeling sorry for myself.”

At my firm reply, Jeong Hogun pressed his lips together.

The eyes visible through his helmet looked a little sad. That had to be my imagination.

Anyway, if that’s how it is…

Ignoring his reaction, I made my decision.

“We split up as soon as we pass through Deokcheong County. There are too many of us.”

“You mean divide the troops…?”

“All of you. And three people.”

“What?”

I pointed past him toward two figures racing ahead in the distance.

“Three of us are enough to get there first.”

Maybe you’ve heard of it.

Fire King on the left, Bow Saint on the right.

Chapter 943

“You can’t be serious!”

The moment my brief explanation ended, Hyuk Mujin cried out, his face stiff with shock. Then he sighed.

“But… damn it.”

He said no more, but everyone here could tell he’d accepted reality.

“If you rush ahead with your eyes fixed on what’s in front of you, you’ll trip over a rock. I know how hard this is for everyone, but for now, this is our best course.”

Namho addressed everyone with a serious expression.

He might have sounded like a seasoned elder, too—if he hadn’t been tucked into Taishan’s arms like a baby kangaroo.

“…I’ve been meaning to ask. Why are you riding like that?”

“Because it’s the most comfortable.”

Namho answered with unnecessary firmness, then added, “If I ride behind him, my ass feels like it’s going to get crushed. If I sit on his shoulder, a branch smacks me in the face every fifteen minutes. An old man like me would die before we reached Shanxi Province.”

Taishan, whose thighs were softer than a genuine leather sofa, nodded.

“Taishan save Namho.”

Since when had those two gotten so close?

I was still wondering why Taishan looked downright solemn when Namho smiled with satisfaction and pulled something from his pack.

“Good lad. Open wide. Here comes the five-spice pork.”

“Oh! Five! Spice! Pork!”

“…”

Right. I’d thought something was off.

I shook my head and eased my horse’s pace for a moment before speaking.

“Elder Namho, please make contact with the Murim Alliance as soon as you leave Zhejiang Province. They’ll be making preparations of their own.”

“I intended to do that anyway. As things stand, I’d only be a burden. I’ll try to lead the reinforcements and follow behind you.”

There wasn’t a single martial artist to be found in Zhejiang Province, where the Imperial Capital stood—let alone a sect.

But Anhui and Henan, which lay along our route to Shanxi Province, were another matter.

Henan was home to the Murim Alliance headquarters, of course. And closest to our current position stood a great power: the Namgung Family.

“Ilseom. Ma Pyo.”

At my call, Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo rode over and answered in turn.

“I’m listening, Pavilion Master.”

“I’ve lost count of how many times I’ve said this, but Sama is my surname, not my given name. Next time you call me…”

“I know. I’m doing it on purpose.”

At my firm reply, Sama Pyo muttered to himself, “Yeah, I thought so.”

“Enough. I trust you both know what you have to do.”

Song Ilseom and Sama Pyo were formidable martial artists despite their youth. Both nodded solemnly.

“Of course.”

“Trust us. Even if something goes wrong along the way, we’ll get everyone to Shanxi Province without a problem.”

I answered their determined assurances with, “Don’t fight each other.”

“…!”

“…!”

“Don’t start bickering in front of the Embroidered Uniform Guards. It’s embarrassing. Got it?”

“…”

“…”

“Answer me.”

The two of them stared at me with flat expressions, then let out quiet laughs. They both knew better than anyone that I was only joking.

“Understood.”

“I’ll try.”

“Did you hear that, Mujin?”

Hyuk Mujin, who’d been watching me in silence, nodded without a word.

He understood the situation and didn’t say anything more, but there was no hiding the emotions in his troubled expression.

He was hurt that I was leaving him behind without hesitation, and angry at himself for being nothing but a burden right now.

“Quit looking so miserable. Your face is ugly enough already—you’re making it worse.”

I let out a short laugh. Hyuk Mujin’s expression darkened further.

“Is that all?”

“Hm?”

“Why… haven’t you asked me to do anything?”

The smile I’d been forcing onto my face faltered.

His question caught me by surprise. I hadn't expected him to think of it that way, and for a moment I didn't know what to say.

After looking at him in silence for a moment, I answered calmly.

"Because you'll do just fine without me asking."

"…!"

"Shanxi Province is where you've lived your whole life, and the Jin Family of Taiyuan is your second home. I know how you must feel right now."

Hyuk Mujin's eyes trembled as he looked at me.

Crack.

Both his fists were turning white.

He glared at the reins clenched so tightly in his hands they looked ready to tear and muttered, "Captain, you wouldn't understand. What it feels like to have something you have to protect, but not the strength to step in. To be left helpless, doing nothing but watch."

"…What?"

"No, forget it. I said something stupid. You're the one who has it hardest right now… I sincerely apologize."

I silently watched him bow his head, his face red.

I wanted to tell him I understood that feeling, too. That I'd felt it all too clearly, down to my soul shattering and my bones breaking.

But I couldn't bring myself to say it.

Sometimes, comfort from the strong can make the weak feel even more powerless and wretched.

And the cruel truth that there are things you can't protect even when you have strength was something Hyuk Mujin couldn't understand yet.

So all I could do for the man who couldn't lift his head, weighed down by shame and guilt, was say one thing.

"I trust you. More than anyone."

"…Captain."

"I'll see you in Shanxi. No—at the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

Pat.

I patted his trembling shoulder in farewell, then spurred my horse forward.

The wind felt colder than before. As I tightened my grip on the reins, hoofbeats approached and a quiet voice reached my ears.

"Hyuk Mujin didn't mean what he said."

It wasn't just the hoofbeats drawing closer. I caught the scent of flowers and managed a smile.

"I know."

"Do you know something?"

"What?"

I turned, puzzled, and saw Ju Hwaran beside me, her expression calm.

"Some smiles can look almost precarious."

"…!"

"I want more than anything to go with you, too, but I know I'd only be a burden, so I won't complain. Still…"

Ju Hwaran smiled like moonlight spilling from the sky.

"When we meet again, let's smile for real. Both of us."

I watched her in silence, then spoke.

"We will. I promise."

And in the next instant, I sprang from the saddle without a moment's hesitation.

Whoosh!

Cold. The fierce wind whipped my hair around.

A weightless feeling swept through me as I leapt high into the air. Behind me, two pale figures cut through the dim moonlight in pursuit.

"Come on. Let's hurry."

At Jeok Cheongang's low voice, the Bow Saint quietly nodded.

I—or rather, we—shot toward the rugged mountain range where no horse could travel.

Whoooosh!

"Well, that's strange."

At his companion's sudden mutter, the bandit dozing against a tree opened his eyes to slits.

"What is?"

He'd just woken from a light sleep, so he was hardly going to sound friendly.

At the brusque voice of a senior bandit more than ten years his elder, his companion swallowed nervously.

"It's nothing, sir. It's just… the longer I sit here, the more something feels off."

"Something's off? I don't see anything."

The bandit tilted his head. His companion pointed at the sky.

"There aren't any birds around today. It's quiet as the grave. Doesn't it feel a little unsettling?"

"Huh?"

The bandit's eyes widened. Only then did he take a careful look around.

Now that he thought about it, it was true.

The sky was empty, and there wasn't a single birdsong from the dense forest stretching in every direction, though the calls should have been constant.

What's going on?

The question flashed through his mind, but his face soon settled into indifference.

What difference did a few missing birds make?

They might call themselves bandits, but they were only low-ranking lackeys. Their sole job was to watch their assigned stretch of mountain road until their eyes popped and contact the stronghold when travelers appeared.

"Maybe a hawk came around. Those birds don't want to get snatched up and eaten in the blink of an eye, so they're keeping their beaks shut."

"Oh, come to think of it, I did see a few hawks fly by earlier."

"Earlier? When?"

"About two hours ago, I think. Four or five of them, flying like arrows."

The bandit must have missed them while he was asleep.

He stroked his shaggy beard and muttered, "That *is* a little strange. Hawks do whatever they please. I've hardly ever seen them travel in a flock."

"Should I report it to the stronghold?"

"Report it? To the stronghold?"

"Yes. The deputy chief said to report anything unusual right away."

"Not a bad idea. If you want to be chopped up alive."

"…"

"The deputy chief's probably fast asleep by now. Wake him, and you won't like what happens. Disturb him over something like that and he might throw an axe at you."

The bandit let out a long yawn and sprawled in the deep shade, stretching his arms and legs.

He still had a hangover from last night, and dozing against a tree had left his body stiff. This time, he meant to sleep until his back hurt.

He left everything to his younger companion, who still had plenty of enthusiasm.

"Quit trying so hard. Just watch for people. People."

With the Double Ninth Festival[3449] not far off, merchants weren't the only ones hoping for a big score.

The bigger the rice cake, the more crumbs there were to collect.

If they picked the right procession—a sizable merchant group or Escort Bureau—the tolls alone would fill the stronghold's storehouse.

Just like now.

"They're—they're coming!"

[3449] The Double Ninth Festival is observed on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month. It is traditionally associated with climbing to high places and chrysanthemums.

"What? What?"

Wham!

At his companion's hushed cry, barely a moment later, the bandit sprang up as if something had launched him and grabbed his axe in a panic.

Any trace of sleep was gone. His eyes shone like a hawk's as he stared down the shadowed mountain road.

"Contact the stronghold. Hurry!"

"Y-Yes, sir!"

The bandit glanced after his companion as he ran off, then narrowed his eyes at the road.

He could see them. Clearly.

A few flags, swaying slowly.

And he could sense dozens of people.

That idiot finally got one right.

The bandit studied the flags passing between the branches.

Then he read the helpful lettering on the dark blue silk and learned the identity of these mouthwatering guests.

The Great Namgung Family.

"…!"

Chapter 944

The Great Namgung Family.

The moment the bandit made out the five characters embroidered on the fluttering flag, only one thought came to mind.

Wait. What's the Namgung Family doing here?

Of course, it wasn't impossible.

This mountain range lay at the southeastern edge of Anhui Province, and the Namgung Family was the undisputed ruler of Anhui.

Still, in more than ten years at the mountain stronghold, the bandit had never once seen the Namgung Family's flag nearby.

Why would they come all the way out to a backwater like this…?

Even if a tiger stays in its cave, every beast knows who their king is, who owns this mountain.

The Namgung Family was that tiger.

Rather than hiding in a dark cave, it held Hefei, the heart of Anhui, and commanded dozens of sects.

One roar was enough to rally countless martial artists beneath its flag. That was the power and influence of one of the Five Great Families.

There's no reason for them to come into these rugged mountains.

The range stretched from west to the distant eastern edge for hundreds of li[3450]. Why would the mighty Namgung Family leave the well-maintained main road and come here with only a few dozen people?

The bandit couldn't make sense of it. But his fear, so fierce his heart felt ready to burst, was greater than his confusion.

Goddamn it. What the hell are they hoping to scrounge up out here?

Cursing inwardly, he steadied himself and carefully backed away.

Fortunately, he was several dozen jang[3451] away, on a hill thick with brush. Retreating without drawing attention wouldn't be too difficult.

Rustle, rustle.

For a little over fifteen minutes, he edged backward, avoiding the leaves and branches on the ground.

Once he was sure he was clear of the danger of being spotted, he finally let out the breath he'd been holding.

"Hah… hah."

His back was damp with cold sweat, and both legs trembled as if he'd suffered a stroke.

[3450] In this Chinese setting, one li is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

[3451] One jang is approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Only fifteen minutes or so had passed, but to a bandit who'd just escaped death, it felt longer than half a day.

"I-I'm alive. I'm alive."

He gripped a nearby tree and sighed with relief. Then he suddenly felt sorry for himself.

You pathetic fool. Just look at yourself.

He didn't regret becoming a bandit.

What could he do about it? He'd somehow been born, somehow lived, and somehow ended up here.

Still, if he was going to make his living this way, he should at least have joined a sizable mountain stronghold.

If he belonged to one of the Seventy-Two Strongholds under the Green Forest Alliance, merely seeing the Namgung Family's flag wouldn't make him fear for his life.

If you're going to be a servant, you might as well serve in a lord's house.

Had anything his drunkard father said ever hit so close to home?

The bandit wiped his eyes with his ragged sleeve and started back down the rugged mountain path.

Lord's house or doghouse, either way, it was a house for a servant. He needed to get back to the stronghold and warn his brothers, who should be on their way here by now after receiving the signal.

If they ran into the Namgung Family when they weren't even members of the Green Forest Alliance, they were as good as dead.

Thank Heaven they're still some distance away. If I head back now, we can all escape in time.

Perhaps Heaven was moved by this noble display of camaraderie, because before another fifteen minutes had passed, the bandit encountered the fifty or so brothers led by their imposing chief.

More precisely, he found their chief sprawled out, while his brothers were, for some reason, lying with their heads pressed to the ground.

"I never meant to block your way, sir. So please, just…"

An unfamiliar back. An ominous feeling he couldn't explain.

The deputy chief was earnestly explaining something to a bald man and a woman standing before everyone when he spotted the bandit watching blankly from some forty yards away. His eyes widened.

"Huh?"

Something was wrong. Very wrong.

The bandit sensed the danger and spun around. That was when—

Poke.

A finger prodded his cheek. An uninvited guest had appeared right in front of him and was studying him.

“Who are you?”

“…!”

The bandit shuddered as if struck by lightning.

First, because he hadn’t sensed a trace of the man’s presence.

And second, because the stranger was much younger than he’d expected.

A master…!

A chill ran down his spine.

With his life hanging in the balance, the bandit barely managed to force out an answer.

“I-I’m Jang Il. My name is Jang Il.”

The world was definitely unfair.

The man was absurdly young, stronger than he’d imagined, and even looked like a courtesan’s pretty-boy brother. He asked again.

“Good. Jang Il. What do you do?”

“Trees. Trees.”

“I asked what you *do*. What the fuck do trees have to do with it? Are you a forest spirit? Jangquines, King of the Spirits?[3452]”

“N-No. I meant to say I’m a woodcutter, but…”

“Right, Jang Il. A woodcutter.”

The young man gave a small nod and glanced at the axe hanging from the bandit’s waist.

“You’ve got an axe, too. Because you’re a woodcutter, I suppose?”

“Y-Yes!”

“Then where’s your carrier frame?”

“…What?”

“Your carrier frame. You planning to haul all that firewood by hand after chopping it?”

“Well, I…”

The bandit hesitated, then hurriedly added, “Down below! I left it down below.”

“You left it down below. Sure, that happens.”

The young man muttered to himself and shrugged.

“Then let’s ask.”

“…?”

[3452] “Jangquines” combines Jang’s name with Elquines, the spirit king from the Korean fantasy novel *The Spirit King Elquines*.

The bandit didn’t have to ask who he meant. Before he could open his mouth, the young man called toward the thick brush.

“This woodcutter says he left his carrier frame down below. Did you happen to see it on your way up?”

At that moment—

Whoosh.

A gust swept through the bushes, and a half-gray-haired man appeared as if from nowhere. He shook his head.

“I saw nothing. Aside from one bandit fleeing in a panic, that is.”

“Oh, dear.”

The young man glanced at the bandit, who looked ready to faint, and clicked his tongue. Then he respectfully clasped his hands toward the middle-aged man.

“Thank you for letting me know, Great Hero Namgung.”

The Family Head of the Namgung Family, the Heavenly Thunder Sword, Namgung Ryong, clasped his hands in return.

“It’s good to see you again, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

No matter how vast the world, people whose paths had crossed were bound to meet again.

Of course, this meeting wasn’t entirely a matter of chance.

“We received word from the Anhui Provincial Office. We happened to be nearby, so we were able to get here quickly.”

I nodded at Namgung Ryong’s brief explanation.

“So the messenger eagle reached the provincial office.”

“About two hours ago. They were in quite a state over there, saying the Son of Heaven had issued the order himself.”

Well, Namgung Ryong wasn’t Namgung Gil-dong[3453]. He couldn’t just pop up in the east one moment and the west the next.

The imperial messenger eagle had entered Anhui two hours ahead of us and gone straight to the provincial office. After receiving the news, Namgung Ryong had immediately led his family members here. That was how it had happened.

“But how did you know where we were? Especially in a mountain range this damn huge.”

“No matter how vast it is, there are only so many paths. The terrain is rugged, but this is the quickest way through.”

[3453] A play on Hong Gil-dong, a legendary Korean outlaw known for appearing in one place and then another.

An answer befitting the head of the Namgung Family, who knew Anhui Province like the palm of his hand.

Even so, a dark shadow hung over Namgung Ryong's face as he looked at me.

"Is it all… true?"

There was no need to ask what he meant.

The air grew heavy. Then Jeok Cheongang spoke up.

"What, you don't believe him?"

"Of course I do. I only wanted to make sure, because it's a truth I can hardly bring myself to believe."

Everyone felt the same way.

Bloodshed had already swept through Henan, Sichuan, and Yunnan, and even reached the Imperial Capital.

And before the stench of blood had faded, an even more terrible, far greater storm cloud was bearing down on us.

As the head of a family, Namgung Ryong had all the more reason to think of the many people who followed him.

"The Double Ninth Festival[3454]. The Double Ninth Festival…"

He muttered in a low voice, then looked at me with troubled eyes.

"My condolences. I never imagined they'd cross the northern grasslands and set their sights on Shanxi Province."

After a brief silence, I spoke.

"They'll be able to hold them off. They're strong enough."

Even as I said it, I knew the truth.

This was a lie meant to hide what I really thought—something closer to an attempt to comfort myself.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan can't manage it alone.

Even Shaolin Temple, called the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim[3455], and the Sichuan Tang Clan, with its terrifying poisons, had suffered heavy losses.

Fortunately, Qingcheng, Emei, and the Nanman Beast Palace had kept their losses to a minimum and preserved their forces. But there was no denying that they'd faced a tremendous crisis.

And this time, it was Dark Heaven's main force.

This wasn't an attack to steal a divine artifact or destroy a single prestigious sect. It was a true invasion, meant to establish a foothold for an advance into the Central Plains.

At least ten thousand. Maybe more.

Even ten thousand—a staggering force—was only the minimum I was hoping for.

[3454] A traditional festival held on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

[3455] Mount Tai and the Northern Dipper form a Chinese expression for a revered authority in a field.

If everything so far had been a Mutated Gate, this was a Monster Wave.

Just as the Demonic Cult had swept through the Murim half a century ago with the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples.

Damn it.

My chest felt tight. I couldn't stop thinking that if I'd found the missive left by the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord even a little sooner—or if I'd logged out before then—we might have gained some time.

Of course, it was already too late.

I'd lost three full days unconscious, and the Quest that appeared the moment I checked the missive in the iron chest had locked the door connecting me to reality.

It had taken away my last refuge, my place of rest, and forced me to move forward.

As if this were the only path I'd been given.

Then… I'll have to run. With everything I've got.

I quietly clenched my fist and turned to Namgung Ryong, who seemed at a loss for words.

Holding on to a sliver of hope, I asked, "Where is the Azure Sky Sword King?"

Namgung Cheon, the Azure Sky Sword King.

A Supreme Peak master counted among the top three of the Ten Kings, and the Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family.

If he joined us and traveled to Shanxi, we could hold off even more enemies than I'd imagined. I already had two fighters at my side who could each take on ten thousand men: the Fire King and the Bow Saint.

But that brief hope vanished when Namgung Ryong answered with a quiet sigh.

"My father has been away from the family estate for a couple of months now."

"Ah."

"I'm afraid we don't even know where he is. All we know is that he took on a mission at the request of Great Hero Mae Jonghak, the Alliance Leader."

I hadn't expected things to work out so easily. Still, I couldn't help feeling disappointed.

"I see."

"Still, as Family Head of the Namgung Family, I'll help you and the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I've had fine horses, enough food, and a family member to guide you along the fastest route made ready, so you can set off at once…"

Just as Namgung Ryong was about to continue—

Grrk. Krrk.

With a muffled, strangled growl, a figure rose from the shadows.

Chapter 945

Grrk. Krrk.

What should I call that?

A groan? Or a roar?

Whatever it was, one thing was certain.

The burly man slowly rising to his feet was moving farther and farther away from the word *ordinary*.

“Who is that…?”

Namgung Ryong studied him with a questioning look.

He had no way of knowing. Before Namgung Ryong arrived, the man had happened upon Jeok Cheongang, attacked him without knowing what he was getting into, and been knocked unconscious with a single punch.

“He’s a bandit.”

“A bandit?”

“Yes. And he’s the head of the bunch.”

I tapped the top of my head. Namgung Ryong caught my meaning at once and nodded.

“I can see why that man was acting like their leader.”

His gaze grew more intent as he studied the man.

“Though I don’t know if an ordinary bandit chief could look like that.”

Ssshhh.

Hot breath spread through the air.

The man exhaled vapor through his clenched teeth. I stared at him—or, more precisely, at the translucent holographic window that had just appeared above his head.

> **System** Lv. 60 Jang Sam

A painfully common name. A face that looked like a bandit at a glance.

But the change that had come over him in those few moments was unmistakable.

It wasn’t just the whites of his eyes or the hot breath pouring from his mouth. The number before his name proved it.

His Level… went up.

Of course, this wasn’t the first time I’d seen someone’s Level change.

Masters who had reached the realm of Returning to Simplicity, or something close to it, could control their qi freely. Even Qi Sense couldn’t accurately read their Level.

But this bandit chief was different.

He wasn't a master of Returning to Simplicity, nor had he gained enlightenment and raised his Level that way.

And people don't jump twenty Levels all at once.

A backwater bandit chief who'd been only Level 40 had suddenly leaped up twenty steps.

How was I supposed to make sense of that?

"This is way beyond anything I know. Care to explain?"

The moment I asked—

Whoosh.

A huge fist came down over my head with a heavy whistle.

Crash!

One step. I'd barely shifted to the side when the ground caved in, sending grass and dirt flying.

He could never have struck with that kind of force before he passed out.

I narrowed my eyes at him. Somehow, he'd acquired a considerable amount of internal energy, too.

He's completely lost it.

I'd suspected as much from the whites of his eyes, but he'd all but lost his reason. Maybe he hadn't even woken up of his own accord.

A man in his right mind wouldn't attack me here unless he had a death wish.

"Raaaagh!"

"…Well, then."

There was no helping it.

As he charged at me like a wild beast again, I slipped in close and gently extended my hand.

Tap.

My palm touched his chest.

At the same time, a faint heat—one I'd worked hard to suppress, over and over—burst out through my palm.

Boom!

With a sound like compressed air exploding, his eight-cheok[3456] frame shot away like a cannonball and slammed into a tree.

Kraaaash!

Beyond the thick cloud of dust, I grabbed his motionless body with one hand and dragged him back. The bandits' eyes widened.

"We're short on time, so I'll keep this brief."

[3456] Eight *cheok* is about 2.42 meters (7.95 ft); one *cheok* is 30.3 cm (11.9 in).

As they stared in shock and fear, I went on in a low voice.

“Tell me everything you know. If you want to live.”

Every man lives with some dream tucked away in a corner of his heart.

It might be a red sports car with a price tag of a hundred million won,[3457] or a study that practically reeks of professional success.

I was no different.

As a teenager, I dreamed of owning a motorcycle. I wanted to put my girlfriend on the back and open it up.

Of course, I didn’t know then that ten years later, I’d still have no girlfriend.

Or that instead of straddling a sleek motorcycle or a red convertible, I’d be riding an eco-friendly, four-wheel-drive thoroughbred and saying this to a man:

“Hold my waist tight, you bastard. You want to fall off the saddle?”

“Y-Yes!”

“But don’t grab too hard. If you pinch me, you’ll die.”

“Eek! I’m sorry, I’m sorry!”

Thud-thud-thud!

The thunder of hooves mingled with a tearful voice.

Maybe Namgung Ryong and the authorities had already made arrangements, because nothing got in the way of us as we rode nonstop at full speed.

Only one thing bothered me: the guy behind me wouldn’t stop sniffling.

“So, Jangquines.”[3458]

“…Yes.”

Jang Il answered, sounding half resigned. He was the bandit who’d pretended to be a woodcutter who’d lost his carrying frame until I’d caught him at his real trade.

He’d been a bandit for more than ten years. He was at the bottom of the pecking order, but there was one thing that set him apart from the others.

“You’ve known that guy for ten years?”

“Yes. I’ve known him since I first got into this line of work. For a while, we were like blood brothers.”

“Brothers, my ass. You’re a bandit. What a load of bullshit.”

Jeok Cheongang had been listening as he rode beside us. At his candid opinion, the Bow Saint frowned and clicked her tongue softly.

“Stay out of it and let him finish.”

[3457] One hundred million won is about $71,000 or €65,000.

[3458] “Jangquines” blends the surname Jang with Guinness, as in Guinness World Records.

“What? Am I not allowed to talk to myself anymore?”

“You really haven’t changed. Apart from losing your hair, you’re just like you were back then…”

“Have you quite finished?”

Jeok Cheongang’s gaze turned icy. Lately, his hair had been slowly sprouting like shoots in spring, and he’d been tending to it with loving care. He made no attempt to hide his anger.

“That’s enough, you two. You, keep talking.”

Even as the two Supreme Peak masters exchanged cold looks, the horses kept running. Jang Il swallowed hard and continued.

“A-Anyway, I followed the chief from then until now. When he said we were moving the stronghold to Anhui Province, everyone called him crazy and left, but I followed him on nothing but faith and loyalty.”

“You moved the stronghold to Anhui Province?”

“Yes. We were near Hubei before, but one day the chief suddenly decided we were moving. Everyone was dead set against it.”

Jang Il smacked his lips, as if remembering the day, then went on.

“Truth be told, I didn’t say anything, but I was thinking of quitting this life and leaving before it was too late.”

“Why? Was moving the stronghold that big a deal?”

“Oh, you don’t understand. Packing up and going is only a bit of work. The problem is, Anhui has the Namgung Family.”

I frowned. Even at a glance, what Jang Il was saying didn’t quite make sense.

“That’s no reason. Wudang and the Zhuge Clan were in Hubei, where you were before.”

Jang Il immediately shook his head.

“It’s not about how many great sects there are. It’s about *which* ones are nearby.”

“Oh.”

“Wudang and the Zhuge Clan are relatively mild. Most of the time, they settle things without bloodshed. But the Namgung Family…”

Jang Il trailed off and shuddered.

“Maybe that’s why the martial artists of Anhui don’t show any mercy, either. If things go wrong, you’d better be ready to lose your head.”

It was so ridiculous I could hardly believe it.

Bandits, carefully weighing up which martial artists might come after them.

But there was something strange about the chief’s choice all the same. As if the Namgung Family weren’t enough, he’d set up his stronghold on the border between Anhui and Zhejiang, close to the Imperial Capital.

“When did you move the stronghold?”

“Probably… three months ago? Around then.”

“What about the other bandits? It sounds like everyone from your old stronghold ran off.”

“They say a pine caterpillar should stick to pine needles, but when we got here, we found some bold bastards playing bandit in Anhui without even belonging to the Green Forest Alliance.”

“So your chief brought them under his command?”

“That’s right. One day, he left me behind and went off alone. He came back having absorbed two small strongholds.”

Jang Il added sadly, “And here I am, still at the bottom of the pecking order.”

I had no interest in an aging bandit’s complaints. As the wind brushed through my hair, I thought, *Even if they were small, he took over two strongholds all by himself?*

Of course that was bullshit.

Before his Level went up, the man had been no more than a middling Second Rate fighter, relying on some tiny amount of internal energy—who knew how he’d built it up—and his natural strength.

At best, he was on the threshold of First Rate. That wouldn’t be nearly enough.

You had to be somewhere around Supreme First Rate before you could even talk about having a chance against dozens of people at once. And that was assuming your opponents were at least a notch below you.

“So he had something to fall back on after all.”

“Pardon?”

“The man you followed as chief. He wasn’t that strong, was he? What gave him the confidence to move to Anhui and bring two strongholds together?”

“Well…”

Jang Il hesitated, then nodded.

“I found it strange myself. He was strong by my standards, but his martial arts weren’t anything special…”

Anywhere under Heaven, a bandit who made a name for himself in his region eventually had two choices.

He could trust in his decent martial arts and swagger around until disciples of a great sect came to wipe him out, or he could join the Green Forest Alliance.

For river bandits, it was the Yangtze River Channel League.

No neighborhood shop could beat a corporation.

Become an officially recognized franchisee of the Green Forest Alliance, and you’d have to pay substantial taxes. But as long as you didn’t openly commit atrocities, you could avoid being hunted down by the great sects.

You went from being a mere bandit to part of a symbiotic system that at least followed a few basic rules.

But that man fit neither category.

After ten years without making a name for himself, he'd set up a stronghold within spitting distance of Zhejiang Province, where the Imperial Capital stood.

Even if he hoped to make a killing around the Double Ninth Festival,[3459] it made no sense.

Neither did the way he'd suddenly grown so much stronger.

You couldn't even call this a fortuitous encounter.

Together, those strange events brought back a memory from more than a year ago.

Pung Yang. Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader.

The leader of the mounted bandits who'd set his sights on the Mount Heng Sword Sect—no, on Shanxi Province.

And the one item that had given him such grand ambitions.

The Temporary Strength Pill…!

[3459] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Chapter 946

Time is impartial.

To the living, the dead, and even things without form.

And so, the name that suddenly came to mind had begun to fade with time. If not for the fierce battle that day and the item I'd happened to get my hands on after winning, I might have forgotten it soon enough.

The Temporary Strength Pill…!

Was this what it felt like to be struck by lightning on the crown of your head?

The shock rattled my mind, and my body went rigid before I knew it.

No way.

My first reaction was denial. But I knew better than anyone why I wanted to reject the thought that had just crossed my mind: I didn't want to believe it.

"What did that bastard—your leader—have?"

"Pardon?"

"Some secret that didn't sit right. A strange item he didn't have before. Whatever it was, remember."

"G-Great Hero, what on earth do you mean…?"

Jang Il, who'd been clinging to my back like a leech, asked in a trembling voice.

Instead of answering, I fought to keep my grip from tightening around the reins.

We couldn't stop here. We had to keep riding, if only for another moment.

Stopping the horse now wouldn't change anything.

"There must have been something strange. I'm sure of it."

"P-Please, wait. Please calm down, Great Hero."

Jang Il looked completely flustered. I was beginning to regret not bringing his unconscious leader instead when—

"…Huh?"

A dazed voice reached my ears. I whipped my head around to find Jang Il staring back at me, eyes wide.

"Come to think of it, at some point he started carrying a silk pouch everywhere."

"A silk pouch?"

"Yes. I remember it clearly. A few months ago, an unlucky traveler passed through our stronghold in Hubei, and the chief took it from him instead of a toll. After that, he kept it close like it was some kind of sacred relic. I thought it might be precious musk or something."

A traveler in Hubei.

A mysterious silk pouch the leader had kept close.

And his inexplicable behavior afterward.

"Um, was there something wrong with the pouch? I did wonder about it a little, since it didn't have the distinctive smell of musk."

I didn't answer Jang Il's question.

No—I couldn't.

My ominous suspicion had just become a certainty. And I knew there was nothing more Jang Il could tell me. What had been inside the silk pouch, and who the traveler who'd owned it was—he wouldn't know even decades from now.

There's no doubt. It was the Temporary Strength Pill.

The Temporary Strength Pill did just what its name suggested: it drew out all the strength latent within the body. Having experienced its dangers firsthand when I fought Pung Yang, I could only grit my teeth.

Crunch.

"What is it?"

Jang Il wasn't the only one who'd noticed something was wrong. I looked at Jeok Cheongang, whose face had gone rigid, and steadied my breathing.

"Do you remember what happened in Shanxi Province?"

"When do you mean?"

"I mean the mounted bandits who attacked the Mount Heng Sword Sect. I told you about them once before."

Strictly speaking, Jeok Cheongang had arrived in Shanxi Province just after the Mount Heng Sword Sect affair had ended. But he was one of the few people who knew all about Pung Yang and the Temporary Strength Pill.

"…Then could it be?"

His eyes widened as he realized what I was getting at.

"Yes," I said quietly. "It's likely. No—given the circumstances, there's no doubt."

"Goddamn it."

Jeok Cheongang let out the curse like a sigh. The Bow Saint, who'd been listening to us with a grave expression, spoke up.

"This is about that bizarre pill, isn't it?"

"…!"

"Don't look so surprised. It may have been in the past, but it was only a year or two ago. I already knew about the Mount Heng Sword Sect and the Red Wind Band."

Unfazed by my reaction, she continued.

"I know you were careful to keep it quiet, but unless you silence the witnesses, the truth has a way of getting out."

The shock of remembering the Temporary Strength Pill had made me forget why the Bow Saint had chosen to stay by the Emperor's side—and just how many eyes and ears the imperial court had scattered across this vast land.

"If you already know, there's no need for a long explanation."

A faint, inscrutable smile touched the Bow Saint's lips as I regained my composure. It vanished as quickly as it had appeared.

"What happened at the Mount Heng Sword Sect raised questions for me, too. Especially after I learned more about Pung Yang, the leader of the Red Wind Band."

Setting everything else aside, any martial artist would have had questions.

That day, in front of a fair number of onlookers, Pung Yang had displayed power approaching the Supreme Peak realm. He'd already become an accomplished Peak master, making him a formidable fighter in his own right. But manifesting Force, even imperfectly, defied common sense.

Especially when the Head Elder, who'd reached the very limits of the Peak realm, could only show power like that after drawing on his innate qi.

Learning martial arts was like climbing an endless flight of stairs. A beginner might skip several steps at once, but at the Peak realm, you had to give everything you had just to reach the next one.

Even Cheongpung, born with heaven-sent martial talent and strengthened at a dazzling pace, wouldn't have skipped the steps laid out before him.

But the Temporary Strength Pill makes that possible.

Its effects were tremendous, its side effects terrible, and its power short-lived. Still, it could twist the natural order. There was no way the Bow Saint could have missed that after learning more about Pung Yang.

"At the time, a thought did cross my mind," she murmured. "I wondered if Pung Yang—the man who died because of his greed—might be the one I'd been searching for."

A question occurred to me.

If Pung Yang, not I, had survived that battle—and if he really had been the chosen one—what choice would she have made?

But I swallowed the question. What we were facing now was far too serious.

"It seems… someone is secretly distributing the pill Pung Yang used."

Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint already knew who I meant by *someone*.

Dark Heaven.

The ones who had made the Temporary Strength Pill.

I didn't know exactly when they'd begun preparing for this. But the fact that one had reached the hands of an ordinary bandit was no small matter.

"Are you sure?" Jeok Cheongang asked, his voice low. "From what this old man heard, its effects seem far too weak."

The Bow Saint shook her head before I could answer.

"The bandit who stood in your way hadn't even reached First Rate. Considering the change in him afterward, there are two possibilities."

"What two?"

"Either its power varies according to the user's level. Or…"

Her voice trailed off as she looked toward me.

"Or they reduced its effects," I said, "and reduced the side effects along with them."

"…!"

A brief silence fell. Jeok Cheongang looked between us, his expression heavy, then muttered, "It must be the latter."

"We can't be sure of that yet."

"No. Whatever explanation you come up with, it's only wordplay to avoid facing reality."

He shook his head and continued firmly.

"Everyone in this world wants power. Wealth, fame, strength—whatever form it takes, they want to stand above others. But everything has its price."

Great power came at a great price.

And most people, however fiercely they wished for something, couldn't bring themselves to put in the work to get it. They knew how hard that would be. To gain what they wanted in the future, they'd have to give up the comforts and pleasures they had now.

"But what if the price of a moment's power were one they could bear?"

Then I understood why Jeok Cheongang was so certain—and what he was really trying to say.

"They didn't make it just to bolster their own fighting strength."

"…!"

"How else could Pung Yang, who led a mere band of mounted bandits, or some petty mountain bandit get their hands on it? No—why would Dark Heaven reach out to the likes of them at all?"

No one would touch a bomb. It might go off at the slightest jolt, and its blast could tear you apart just for standing too close.

But what if it wasn't a bomb? What if it was a campfire?

On a cold winter day, people wandering through the snow in search of something would reach toward it for warmth. Even if they got too close, they'd suffer only a small burn. They knew that much wouldn't kill them.

A campfire anyone could reach toward. A trivial price for its warmth.

That was probably exactly what Dark Heaven wanted. This vast land was full of madmen eager to taste power, even at that small cost. And those called the orthodox faction would be no exception.

Power anyone can obtain…!

That was the true danger of the new Temporary Strength Pill.

Its alluring power would tempt people who'd spent ten years, even decades, stuck in the same place. In the blink of an eye, it would addict them and ruin them.

And at the same time, the Lord of Heaven could give greater vitality to his countless followers—or rather, to the people who were little more than disposable meat shields.

To the innumerable hordes of Dark Heaven surging like a wave toward Shanxi Province even now.

Chapter 947

I'd known for a long time that danger was coming—danger we might not be able to contain.

I'd watched the enormous blaze called Dark Heaven draw closer with my own eyes.

But there was one thing I hadn't known.

Another blaze was approaching from behind.

Its heat had begun spreading who knew when, burning through us from deep within, consuming our very organs.

If the newly improved Temporary Strength Pill spreads throughout Murim…

It won't be a simple blaze anymore.

It'll be a bomb.

A time bomb that'll suddenly go off with a bang when the moment comes.

Just as drug addicts in the modern world keep using even when they know it's destroying their minds and bodies, martial artists won't be able to stop.

No. They'll be worse.

Martial artists are lunatics who'll do anything to get stronger.

Their desire to master martial arts is pure and primal—and that makes it more dangerous than anything else.

All the more so because that desire transcends the values of the orthodox, unorthodox, and demonic paths.

"They've… poisoned Murim."

Jeok Cheongang's grim murmur cut straight to the heart of our situation.

Poison.

He was right. This was poison.

The deadly poison of desire, which even the Myriad-Poison Ring couldn't cure.

And among those present, only one person had yet to grasp that: a bumpkin mountain bandit.

"P-Poison? What do you mean by that, sir?"

Jang Il looked thoroughly confused.

But no one answered him.

"You there. Your ears working?"

At Jeok Cheongang's abrupt question, the Namgung Family martial artists guiding us stiffened and replied.

"Of course, Great Hero Jeok."

"The Family Head told us to treat you as we would him. Give us your orders whenever you like."

"Orders, you say? Glad to hear it."

Jeok Cheongang nodded, then gave me a look.

There was a reason I'd spoken about something so important out loud even with Jang Il here.

It was because of them.

We need to get the word out as soon as possible.

The unconscious bandit chief, who should be bound and on his way to the Namgung Family by now, was the key to this whole affair.

He'd already lost half his mind, so there was little chance he'd be sane when he woke. But an interrogation might still yield something important.

"Effective immediately, I'm changing part of your assignment."

Namgung Cheon had sent four guides with us.

I looked at three of them in turn and gave them their new orders.

"One of you, go to the Namgung Family right now. Another, return to Great Hero Namgung and tell him what we've learned. And the last one…"

"To the Anhui provincial government?"

Quick to understand. That made this easier.

I nodded and continued.

"Tell the City Lord directly. He's to mobilize every soldier he can, tighten security, and investigate everything connected to this."

Dark Heaven's improved Temporary Strength Pill had begun circulating months ago. No matter how discreet they'd been, a thorough investigation would turn up traces.

And if the City Lord himself, with at least ten thousand troops under his command, got involved, he could search even the remote places beyond the Namgung Family's reach.

"I'll relay your orders. But I'm not sure the City Lord will go that far for us…"

The Namgung Family martial artist let his words trail off. I thought I knew what he was getting at.

The government and Murim had stayed out of each other's affairs since time immemorial.

The Emperor had declared war on Dark Heaven, but he'd done so by backing the Murim Alliance. This was a cooperative arrangement.

The City Lord, a servant of the Great Nation to his very bones, wouldn't be pleased to hear this before he even understood what was really going on.

Especially when it came from martial artists. Officials and martial artists had spent years barely acknowledging each other, and this was an order in all but name.

"That's true. He might not."

The Namgung Family martial artist hesitated at my mutter, then shook his head.

“No. Don’t worry. Even if the City Lord objects, the Family Head can make a strong request in the Namgung Family’s name—”

“Well, there’s no need to go that far.”

“Pardon?”

“Do you have any paper? Oh, never mind. This’ll do.”

Riiip.

Leaving the Namgung Family martial artist blinking in confusion, I spread the strip of cloth I’d just torn off against the horse’s head.

At the same time, I gave a silent command.

Open Inventory. Summon.

Ding.

Along with a clear chime, a cool sensation reached the hand I’d been feeling around inside my robe with, just to keep up appearances.

“What’s that…?”

“Just a moment.”

The Namgung Family martial artist stared at the object in my hand. I ignored his questioning look and poured Scorching Yang Qi into it.

Hummm.

With a faint tremor, the ornately decorated silver plaque grew red-hot. So did the characters painstakingly engraved into it, no doubt by a renowned imperial artisan.

Ssssss.

The heated silver plaque met the dark blue silk.

After a few seconds of breathing in acrid smoke, I lifted it away. A blackened design and characters marked the torn strip of cloth.

Great Marquis of Shangshan.

“It’s a little messy, but they’ll be able to make it out, right?”

“…!”

“…!”

Silence fell.

The sound of hooves filled the space where no one answered. Before I knew it, everyone except Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint was staring at me, eyes wide.

“W-What on earth is this?”

“You didn’t know? It’d take too long to explain. Just take this to the City Lord for now, and make sure he knows it’s an order, not a request.”

The Namgung Family martial artists were still gaping at me.

“If he acts offended even after seeing it, tell him this. Word for word.”

"W-What should we tell him?"

I answered the trembling question without hesitation.

It was a rule that held true in Murim, the modern world, and even a fantasy world crawling with nest-building dragons.

"If I say do it, you do it."

"…!"

What rank did a City Lord hold in the official hierarchy?

The question briefly crossed my mind, but I knew one thing for certain. Now that I'd formally joined the ranks of the marquises, he was several rungs below me.

"Oh, one more thing. The reinforcements will arrive within a day or two at the latest."

The mouths that had hung open moments ago clamped shut.

One of the silent Namgung Family martial artists forced out his voice.

"R-Reinforcements?"

"People from the Murim Alliance's Fire Dragon Pavilion. And a thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards."

"…!"

"Stick close to the City Lord and keep an eye on him. If he seems really suspicious, tell them they can take his head."

Anhui was close enough to the imperial capital that you could almost get there in a hop, skip, and a jump. The City Lord would have to be insane to harbor any other intentions. But that wasn't proof Dark Heaven hadn't gotten its claws into him.

"Is… is that really allowed?"

I answered the dazed question calmly.

"It is. I can."

We were at war. Besides holding the exalted title of marquis, I was a Thousand Captain in the Embroidered Uniform Guard, which answered directly to the imperial household.

Unless he belonged to the imperial family—no, even if he did—I had more than enough authority to punish him.

And all of that authority and prestige came from the Emperor.

The Son of Heaven put a sword in my hand himself. I'd better swing it without hesitation.

I hadn't accepted this sword to enjoy riches and glory or to look impressive.

I'd been given a sword and a title to cut down the enemies in my path and protect my people.

If reaching that goal meant dancing with a sword until I collapsed, I could do that.

"Now, let's split up."

At my abrupt words, the Namgung Family martial artists finally came to their senses. They'd been staring at me blankly even as their saddles jolted beneath them.

"We obey!"

Thud-thud-thud!

With a fervent shout that sounded like they'd forgotten who they worked for, three of them wheeled their horses around and galloped toward their respective destinations.

That left one guide to lead us to the border between Anhui and Henan—and someone we'd all forgotten about for a moment.

"I-I obey!"

"…?"

The belated reply came from behind me.

I turned and met Jang Il's eyes. The bandit wore a look of entirely unnecessary determination.

"For the sake of the realm, I'll do everything in my power to help—"

"Get off. Unless you want to die."

"Yes, sir."

Anyone who'd lived through war even once knew.

The air around them. The wind. The sunlight. The people.

Everything was different from usual.

An inexplicably heavy, ominous darkness rippled through the world.

Perhaps that was why the old man couldn't relax, even after waking from his first long, deep sleep in ages.

"Damn, the weather's shitty today."

Anyone who heard him mutter that would have scoffed and called the old man senile.

The sky beyond the lattice window was blue, and strong sunlight poured through the few scattered clouds.

But if that person were a martial artist—or simply lived in Hebei—they wouldn't dare meet his eyes.

The old man scowling out the window was as renowned throughout the realm as he was enormous: a towering figure, and a living legend.

"Is nobody there?"

Even a beast's quietest roar could make its surroundings tremble. The old man's voice rattled the pavilion, and those nearby responded in an instant.

“Have you woken, sir?”

At the deep voice outside the door, the old man gulped down cold water and wiped his mouth.

“Where’s Cheolyeong, that bastard?”

“The Family Head is in the Inner Hall, attending a meeting.”

“A meeting?”

“Yes. It began two shichen[3460] ago.”

“Have they all gone mad? And nobody woke me?”

At the old man’s growl, the person outside the door caught their breath, then answered carefully.

“W-Well…”

“Got an excuse?”

“You said you’d rearrange our five viscera and six bowels[3461] if we woke you while you were sleeping soundly.”

“Oh.”

The old man scratched the back of his head.

Now that he thought about it, he had said that.

He hadn’t been sleeping well lately, and it had put him on edge. Then he’d finally fallen into a deep sleep and forgotten all about it.

“Damn it. I finally got a good long sleep, so I guess something must’ve happened.”

Clicking his tongue softly, the old man got up.

He knew what kind of men his eldest son, the current head of the family, and the senior members under him were.

If men with nothing but muscle between their ears had been sitting on their asses for two shichen[3462], it had to be serious.

“Go to the Inner Hall. Tell them this old man is coming.”

The eyes of the towering old man—Peng Cheolhu, the Thunderbolt Saber King—grew deep and grave.

[3460] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.
[3461] “Five viscera and six bowels” refers to the organ groupings used in traditional East Asian medicine.
[3462] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

Chapter 948

Servants and maids hurried to clear away furniture broken and smashed in every direction.

Amid the wreckage, as though a typhoon had swept through the room, hulking men stood glaring at one another and breathing hard.

That was what Peng Cheolhu, the Thunderbolt Saber King, saw when he entered the Inner Hall's grand conference room. He took in the scene, looked around, and said, "I'll count to three. No more, no less. If you're not back in your places by then…"

Whoosh!

Before he'd even finished speaking, dozens of hulking men scattered like the wind, returning to their original places.

All but one.

"You're here, Father."

The Thunderbolt Saber King frowned at the greeting from his eldest son, who was nearing seventy.

"You're awfully late with your morning greeting."

"I heard you were sleeping soundly…"

"Cut the nonsense. I thought you were finally ready to act like a proper person, so I handed over the Family Head position—and now you're fighting with your own blood relatives? In this sacred conference room, no less, where we're discussing matters of vital importance to the family!"

Peng Cheolyeong, the Iron Blood Saber and current Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family, silently took the booming rebuke before speaking.

"That reminds me of when you broke Third Uncle's left arm. Here, in this sacred conference room where we discuss matters vital to the family."

The Thunderbolt Saber King faltered, then replied sternly, "I was young and hot-blooded then."

"That was last year."

"…That can't be right."

"And that's not all. The year before, Second Uncle dozed off for a moment during a meeting, so you punched him in the jaw—"

"Now, Family Head!"

Second Uncle rebuked Peng Cheolyeong for daring to talk back to his father, the Grand Family Head. Then he added, "It was my shin. I don't know whose jaw you're thinking of."

"I'm sorry. I mixed them up. That was probably Fifth Uncle."

Fifth Uncle, who had shrunk into a corner the moment the Thunderbolt Saber King appeared, muttered with mournful eyes, “Yes. Three years ago. When I woke up, two days had passed…”

“That’s enough. I get it. Let’s move on.”

Having failed to come out of the exchange with any dignity, the Thunderbolt Saber King shook his head and took the seat of honor.

Fortunately, the sturdy iron chair had survived intact. It had been made to withstand the Hebei Peng Family’s time-honored habit of throwing punches whenever the mood struck.

“Enough nonsense. Everyone, sit down. Tell me what you spent two shichen[3463] shouting and beating each other over.”

Peng Cheolyeong sat beside him and got straight to the point.

“Something’s wrong in the north.”

“The north? Why would the Murong Family suddenly be acting strange?”

The Thunderbolt Saber King’s assumption was only natural. To the Hebei Peng Family, *the north* had always meant the Murong Family.

At the far edge of this vast realm, the descendants of the Xianbei ruled Liaoning Province, a true frontier. Centuries ago, their ancestors had proclaimed themselves kings of a nation; now the family had long held its place among the Five Great Families.

“There’s no way the Murong Family is up to anything. You must have been given bad information.”

The Thunderbolt Saber King waved the matter away as though it wasn’t worth hearing. But Peng Cheolyeong’s next words made his expression harden.

“I wasn’t talking about the Murong Family.”

“What?”

If not the Murong Family, that left only one place.

The true north. A land of outlaws more lawless even than Murim, with schemes and blades lurking everywhere.

“Don’t tell me… you mean those barbarian bastards on the grasslands?”

“Yes.”

Peng Cheolyeong, considered the mildest of the Hebei Peng Family by blood, continued in a calm voice.

“The rumors coming from there are troubling.”

“They’re a vicious lot to the bone, but they’ve been quiet these past few years, haven’t they?”

The Thunderbolt Saber King was right. More precisely, peace and prosperity had begun to settle over the long-troubled grasslands about two years ago.

[3463] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; two shichen are about four hours.

At the center of that change stood the Jin Family of Taiyuan, newly risen to power in the north.

“I heard there’s been no trouble since the Jin Family of Taiyuan formed that Seven-Route Army of theirs and swept through the place. Am I mistaken?”

“You’re exactly right. They went on a single campaign and pulled out the tooth that had been aching for ages.”

After taking control of the Shanxi Murim, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had moved with a speed and boldness that astonished even the Five Great Families and the Nine Sects and One Gang.

They absorbed sects that had once bared their teeth at them, along with Escort Bureaus and merchant houses. With that strength, they formed seven armed forces and swept across the grasslands.

The mounted bandits who regularly crossed the border to pillage and kill could not stand against the Seven-Route Army. Neither could the horse-riding tribes.

In fact, some of them had even rallied beneath the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s banner and reaped a handsome reward for their victories.

“Temur. Chinggen.”

At the foreign names that slipped from his son’s lips, the Thunderbolt Saber King narrowed his eyes.

He had devoted himself to martial arts since stepping back from the front lines, but he remained the Grand Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family in more than name. He remembered nearly everything discussed at the meetings he occasionally attended—even the names of barbarians whose faces he had never seen.

“Those two who sided with the Jin Family of Taiyuan and became Great Chieftains. Am I right?”

“Yes. I hear they’re called khans on the grasslands.”

“Khan or can, I don’t care. What matters is what those bastards are doing.”

The Thunderbolt Saber King tapped the table with fingers like iron rods, lost in thought.

Temur and Chinggen had risen to power on the grasslands thanks to their alliance with the Jin Family of Taiyuan. If they were behaving suspiciously, there were two possible reasons.

They had grown dissatisfied with what they possessed and wanted more.

Or…

“What are the chances they’ve joined hands with Dark Heaven? I could tear those bastards to pieces and still not be satisfied.”

“We don’t know for certain yet,” Peng Cheolyeong said quietly. “But the evidence suggests they’ve conspired with Dark Heaven.”

The Thunderbolt Saber King let out a low groan to himself.

Those bastards wouldn't suddenly try this unless they'd lost their minds. Not when they know Fire King—that crazy old man—is standing right behind the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Everyone knew of Jeok Cheongang's ties to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Rumor held that fear of the Fire King was why Temur and Chinggen had allied with the family, even betraying some of their own people to build the power they now held.

And now they're going to stab him in the back like this? It makes no sense.

Jeok Cheongang was hellfire itself: a blaze that died down only after reducing everything to ash.

The Thunderbolt Saber King was prouder than anyone, but he hated even the thought of becoming the Fire King's enemy in earnest.

Someone's backing them. There has to be.

He studied his eldest son.

"You have a reason for thinking this. What's your evidence?"

"About two years ago, we placed people we could trust on the grasslands."

"Informants… You used your head."

"The situation there was still unstable. We made our move when the new trade routes opened."

Opening a route meant letting people in.

After the Seven-Route Army's campaign, led by the Jin Family of Taiyuan, more than fine ceramics and jewelry passed along the grassland trade routes.

People.

New kinds of people the lawless grasslands had not seen for a long time.

Some of those who filled the vacuum there included informants from the Hebei Peng Family.

"Recently, a few of them sent word that the barbarians on the grasslands are gathering."

"How many?"

"At least ten thousand."

"…What? Ten thousand?"

"Father."

Peng Cheolyeong struggled to speak at the sight of the Thunderbolt Saber King staring at him, eyes wide.

"That's only the number of troops confirmed so far."

"…!"

For a moment, the Thunderbolt Saber King doubted his ears.

Ten thousand. A full ten thousand.

Not a rabble, either, but warriors of a horse-riding people who had once thundered across the continent. Men born on the open plain who died in the saddle.

And that may not even be all of them…

He looked down at his fist. He had clenched it so tightly that his knuckles had gone white.

He could almost see the countless riders charging as one, reins in one hand, bows and lances in the other.

Then fury surged from deep in his chest and blotted out the vision.

"Enough!"

Whoom! Crash!

A powerful wave of qi swept through the room with a thunderous boom. The Thunderbolt Saber King smashed the huge iron table with one punch and rose, glaring at Peng Cheolyeong—no, at everyone in the conference room.

"Were you going to decide a matter this grave without me? Have you all lost your minds?"

Crrrreak.

The giant's power pressed down from every side. The old Grand Family Head's anger shook the conference room as though a typhoon had struck it.

Then Peng Cheolyeong spoke.

"I had to hear everyone's opinions before I told you."

"You fool! The family's survival is at stake!"

His eldest son remained calm—the son he had trusted enough to make Family Head—but the Thunderbolt Saber King's anger would not subside.

Ten thousand already confirmed. If the barbarian force grew to tens of thousands and entered Hebei in fifteen days—or even in a few days—there would be no containing it.

"How dare you…"

Betrayal and disappointment burned through him.

Then Peng Cheolyeong's subdued voice reached his ears.

"Please forgive me. I couldn't risk Hebei Peng Family blood being spilled over a hasty decision. That's all."

"What does that—"

His trembling body went still.

Only then did the Thunderbolt Saber King sense something was wrong. He slowly scanned the faces around him and realized what had struck him as familiar about Peng Cheolyeong's words.

They aren't after our family!

The realization flashed through him like lightning.

Of course. If the grassland forces were already marching south toward Hebei, no one would still be sitting in this conference room. They would be mobilizing the family's forces and the entire Hebei Murim, preparing for battle as fast as they could.

Then… surely not?

His face went rigid.

"Shanxi. It's Shanxi Province."

He had spoken almost to himself, but Peng Cheolyeong quietly nodded.

"When will those goddamn bastards set foot in Shanxi Province?"

Someone answered in a grave voice.

"We expect them within seven days at the latest."

"Do they—the Jin Family of Taiyuan—know?"

"Yes," Peng Cheolyeong said quietly. "They're already preparing for battle."

The Thunderbolt Saber King groaned and raised his head. Beyond the window, dark clouds now filled what had been a blue sky.

Fewer than ten days remained until the Double Ninth Festival.[3464]

[3464] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Chapter 949

Everything has a warning sign.

As an earthquake approaches, the ground rumbles and countless birds take flight all at once. Before a typhoon strikes, featherlike clouds fill the sky.

If even natural disasters—calamities that might as well be divine punishment—give warning, what more need be said of something done by human hands?

Just a few days ago, some people had sensed ominous signs coming from the grasslands.

They were unmistakable.

The nomads. No—the entire grasslands are on the move.

In a vast hall veiled in dimness, an imposing man silently studied the map before him.

It was as large as three or four grown men laid together and crowded with the terrain and place names of the entire continent. Yet his gaze was fixed on one place alone.

Shanxi.

The land where he had been born and raised. The land his ancestors had protected.

A little over three hundred years ago, near the end of the war that had drenched the world in blood, a man had arrived here.

His family name was Jin; his given name, Muryang.

He had been an unwelcome outsider. But in Taiyuan, he laid a foundation stone and raised his banner, and the Jin Family of Taiyuan began.

Even he couldn't have known our family would endure for so long.

A little over three hundred years.

An almost unimaginable span of time.

Flowers beautiful enough to draw gasps and towering trees grand enough to awe all who saw them had fallen to the passing winters and the years.

But the weeds on the frontier—the Jin Family of Taiyuan—still protected this land.

Blooming in profusion, then broken, shattered, and rising again.

"Rise and fall. Flourishing and decline."

Jin Wikyung murmured the words, then slowly continued.

"Our family rose long ago, and we only narrowly escaped ruin. So I thought surely all that remained was for us to flourish…"

He smiled bitterly.

"I had that badly wrong. Don't you think?"

It wasn't a lament to no one, nor was he talking to himself.

Wipeng stood at his post, solid as an iron tower and still as a lake. He spoke.

“Looking at you now, my lord, I’m reminded of the past.”

“The past?”

“It wasn’t so long ago. Only two years.”

“The Mount Heng Sword Sect…”

“That’s right. You looked like this then, too.”

Wipeng’s voice was as cold as the epithet Ghost Sword suggested.

“The fight hasn’t even begun. Are you thinking of laying down your sword before you’ve drawn it?”

“Is that how it looks?”

“To me, yes.”

At his closest retainer’s firm answer, Jin Wikyung bit his lip.

He was ashamed that he couldn’t deny it at once. And the reality that kept him from making a decision even in a moment of stubborn defiance was bleak.

“I’m…the Lesser Family Head of our family. Countless lives depend on a few words or some small action of mine.”

Not only those of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

All of Shanxi Murim moved according to Jin Wikyung’s will. The Jin Family of Taiyuan was unquestionably the foremost power in Shanxi Province, and he was, for all intents and purposes, its Family Head.

Even now, a wave of tens of thousands of men and horses was bearing down on their land.

“I’ve already sent a letter through the Shanxi Provincial Office ordering the evacuation of the people around Datong and Saneum. We have to prevent as many needless casualties as we can.”

Datong and Saneum were the districts closest to the grasslands. They would be the first places trampled when the grassland army crossed the border.

“The Mount Heng Sword Sect must withdraw as well. There’s still time. It’s the only way to save the sect from destruction.”

“Do you think Sect Leader Lee will agree?”

“It isn’t a proposal. It’s an order.”

Jin Wikyung’s voice was subdued.

“She has no other choice. By now, she must have accepted that.”

Over the past two years, the Mount Heng Sword Sect had grown remarkably under the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s banner.

Lee Seowol, its new Sect Leader, had proven far more capable than anyone had expected of a woman in that position.

Her father, the former Sect Leader Lee Cheonbaek—the Blood Wolf Sword—had built the Mount Heng Sword Sect through fear and force. With her intelligence and leadership, she had rebuilt it when it stood on the brink of collapse.

The whole world had taken notice.

But no matter how much the sect had grown, it could not withstand the crisis now on its doorstep.

“Thirty thousand.”

Jin Wikyung met Wipeng’s eyes.

“By the time they reach Shanxi Province, their numbers will have swelled to thirty thousand.”

The past few days had passed with merciless speed.

One day, urgent word had arrived that nomads scattered across the grasslands were gathering. Then several Escort Bureaus and merchant houses along the grassland trade routes had disappeared.

Their fate was obvious. So were the culprits.

“Their aim is clear. So is who’s behind them.”

Jin Wikyung knew Temur and Chinggen well. Support from the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been one of the chief reasons the two men had risen so quickly to power on the grasslands.

“Temur is strong, but utterly simple. Chinggen is calculating and cautious, but his ambitions are limited. Neither would ever attempt something like this. They don’t have the strength for it, either.”

The age when grassland nomads had thundered across the continent with bows and lances was long gone.

The empire they had built had vanished without a trace. Driven onto vast but desolate plains, the nomads had feuded among themselves and dwindled.

“Their strength has been proven. But it still isn’t enough to threaten the Central Plains.”

Temur and Chinggen, now called khans, were still just two among the many Great Chieftains of the grasslands.

And the Central Plains?

Every province had thousands—sometimes more than ten thousand—soldiers of the Great Nation, along with powerful Murim sects.

The divided grasslands. The united Central Plains.

The gulf between them was too deep and wide.

The nomads would never again follow their ancestors’ path to rule the world.

Not unless another great power intervened.

“It isn’t thirty thousand nomads I’m afraid of.”

Jin Wikyung glared at the enormous map, as though waiting for something hidden among its dense lines and characters to spring out.

“Dark Heaven. I’m afraid of the strength they haven’t shown us yet.”

For the past two years, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had gone from strength to strength.

But through all the celebrations and cheers, Jin Wikyung had suffered a terrible nightmare every night.

A nightmare filled with the dead.

“Kill them!”

“Don’t retreat a single step!”

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Eight Spring Gorge.

Every night, Jin Wikyung wandered that bloody gorge, where enemies, allies, and traitors had charged at one another like beasts.

“Lesser Family Head, are you all right—? Cough!”

He watched a family retainer who had always greeted him with a smile collapse in a spray of blood.

“P-Please, spare me. I beg you. I beg you.”

He passed a dying Mount Heng Sword Sect martial artist, eyes wide open, on his way to face another enemy.

“Do you know what you—you, the Jin Family of Taiyuan—did to us?!”

He faced the traitors who had finally drawn the blades they had kept hidden for decades.

He crossed swords with them without pause until, at last, he brought them down and stood before one man.

“Look around you. What do you think as you watch them die so horribly?”

A beard stained red with blood.

A dry gaze. A dry voice.

The Head Elder, who had surely died long ago, spoke to his own blood kin, his breath cold.

“If you had been a little more careful. A little wiser…could you have prevented a tragedy like this?”

Jin Wikyung had no memory of those words.

Of course he didn’t.

They were questions he asked himself.

He knew the Head Elder in his nightmare—and every word the man spoke—came from within him.

Even knowing that, he dreamed it again and again.

Even now.

“My lord.”

Wipeng’s voice suddenly reached him. Jin Wikyung blinked slowly, like a man waking from sleep, and realized his body was damp with cold sweat.

“…Damn it. Look at the state of me.”

Jin Wikyung let out a short curse, then gave a bitter chuckle.

It was ridiculous. He was trembling like a drenched rat.

And the fate of Shanxi Murim—no, of all Shanxi Province—rested in the hands of this pathetic man, who could barely breathe under the pressure closing in from every direction.

His one small comfort was that someone who had stood beside him for so long was still there.

“May I say something, my lord?”

Wipeng’s voice broke the brief silence. He continued without waiting for an answer.

“The enemy is strong. If Dark Heaven’s hidden forces join thirty thousand nomads…you may be right. What happens then may be beyond undoing.”

“Even with the government’s help, we can’t be sure we’d win. Without reinforcements, we couldn’t hold them off with every force Shanxi Province can muster.”

Jin Wikyung added bitterly, “Even if we’re lucky enough to get reinforcements in time, there won’t be nearly enough. Of course there won’t. In their place, I couldn’t leave my family unprotected either.”

A feint to the east, a strike in the west.

The vast grasslands bordered not only Shanxi Province, but Liaoning, Hebei, and Shaanxi as well. The moment the army marching south toward Shanxi turned its horses elsewhere, the sects and families that had sent reinforcements would become its new targets.

And while Dark Heaven possessed the strange dark art known as the Moving Formation, no one could easily leave their sect or family undefended.

They had things to protect, too.

“I intend to abandon Shanxi and head for Henan. As long as our people survive, our family won’t disappear.”

This was neither the best choice nor the second-best.

It was the lesser evil, chosen to avert the worst.

Wipeng understood Jin Wikyung’s desire to prevent so many deaths.

“If that is your command, my lord, I will obey.”

“Wipeng, you…”

“But my lord, do you remember?”

Wipeng spoke calmly.

"Two years ago, someone said that once you start retreating, you'll keep backing away until you trip over a rock and fall."

"…!"

"I know how strong the enemy is. And I know why you've made this decision. But…"

Wipeng drew a deep breath and clasped his hands in salute to the lord he trusted and followed.

"Our Jin Family of Taiyuan has grown stronger. No—Shanxi Murim has grown stronger."

He turned without hesitation and opened the tightly shut door.

Swish.

Jin Wikyung saw them then.

Beyond the slowly opening door, countless people waited, armed and ready.

Familiar faces stood at their head.

"Lee Seowol of the Mount Heng Sword Sect. I've come to fight the foreign enemy."

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Lee Seowol stood in martial attire. Behind her, three hundred Mount Heng Sword Sect martial artists drew their weapons and drove them deep into the ground.

"Sect Leader Lee. What is all this…?"

Jin Wikyung couldn't finish.

He had spotted the dozens of Sect Leaders and Family Heads who had sworn allegiance beneath the Jin Family of Taiyuan's banner two years ago. Each stood armed, eyes cold.

And among them was someone who had just appeared.

"What's got you so worried?"

The young man's voice was rough and awkward, as if he'd forgotten how to speak for a long time.

He smiled at Jin Wikyung, his hollow cheeks standing out.

"Hyung.[3465]"

"…!"

His younger brother had finally emerged into the world after a long seclusion. At the sight of him, Jin Wikyung closed his eyes, unable to contain the emotion rising within him.

And in the instant of darkness, he recalled the voice of his youngest brother, who wasn't there, speaking through Wipeng just moments ago.

Once you start retreating, you'll keep backing away until you trip over a rock and fall.

[3465] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man close to him.

He couldn’t be sure which choice was right or wrong.

But the road ahead was decided.

Step.

He walked toward the people waiting for the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Toward the dark future from which the smell of blood was already drifting.

Chapter 950

For everyone, that summer felt unusually short and chaotic.

The strangely unpredictable weather was only one of many reasons.

Floods no longer even counted as surprising.

One midsummer day, hail fell instead of monsoon rain. On another, the worst heat wave in recorded history was followed by a layer of white frost.

People whose crops were ruined overnight sank to the ground and wept. As grain prices soared, they were left wondering where their next meal would come from.

The government released rice for famine relief, but a sack passed through a few hands and dwindled to a single hop.[3466]

In the end, those who could no longer bear their hunger headed for the mountains.

There they stripped bark from trees to eat, or took up rusted farm tools and became bandits.

But even that wouldn't last long.

What could people who had spent their whole lives dutifully working the fields possibly do? All that awaited these clumsy bandits was death.

Whether by government troops or martial artists, they would eventually be hunted down. And only when cold blades cut through their bodies would a question suddenly occur to them:

How did I end up like this?

But no one knew the answer.

Events across this vast land were often too tangled for anyone to understand.

All the more so when one looked back on the past two years.

"Have you heard? Just a couple of months ago, in Nanman…"

"That's not all. Guangxi has run red with blood."

"This is driving me mad. What's happening to the world?"

Stories circulated wherever people gathered. That was nothing new.

But compared to a few years ago, the mood had changed. No—the very air had changed.

The voices of the people filling the inn hung low as morning fog. Worry showed plainly in their eyes and on their faces.

Rumors about the Murim, once no more than talk to go with a drink, had become real blades, slowly cutting into their skin.

They could no longer laugh and sing.

[3466] A *hop* is a traditional Korean measure of volume, approximately 180 mL or 6.1 US fl oz.

They watched government troops patrol the streets in groups of dozens, and glanced anxiously at the occasional passing martial artist. Before nightfall, they hurried home.

By now, everyone knew it instinctively.

A new war had already begun.

A catastrophe beyond anything the hundred thousand Demonic Cultists who had trampled the Central Plains decades ago could have brought was looming over them.

And those within the world of the Murim felt the reality of it more keenly than anyone.

“I hear they’ve reached all the way into the Imperial Court. They’ve been at it for decades, since around the Great Faction War.”

“I heard the same from the Beggars’ Sect.”

“Dark Heaven is stronger than we thought. It’s a good thing their plan fell through. If it had succeeded…”

It was no longer unusual for dozens of martial artists to gather, especially Sect Leaders and Family Heads.

They discussed the situation in grave voices and tried to predict what would come next.

And one name came up every time.

“The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon distinguished himself again. I hear this earned him the Imperial Court’s active support and the Son of Heaven’s favor.”

“Then is that rumor true?”

“What rumor?”

“You haven’t heard? A few days ago, when the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon left the Imperial Capital, the Son of Heaven himself came out to see him off and made him a marquis.”

“What? The Son of Heaven gave a martial artist an official title—and made him a marquis, no less? Is that even possible?”

“There were plenty of witnesses. It happened in the Imperial Capital, so it took the Lower District Sect and the Beggars’ Sect a little time to get word of it, but it seems to be true.”

News travels a thousand li[3467] without feet.

The Imperial Court’s proclamation declaring Dark Heaven a foreign enemy and announcing war, together with word of Jin Taekyung’s achievements and the unprecedented honor of his elevation to marquis, spread from mouth to mouth in no time.

[3467] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 m or 0.311 mi; three hundred li is about 150 km or 93 mi.

Now even the Imperial Court had stepped in.

The Great Nation, which had sat back and watched even during the Great Faction War, possessed more troops and supplies than anyone could count. If it joined the fight, Dark Heaven would be little more than a candle in the wind.

Or rather, that was what everyone expected.

Everyone except the handful of people who knew the full situation.

Flap, flap!

The old man watched a messenger eagle disappear into the distance, its wings beating hard, then unfolded the tiny scrap of paper in his hand.

As his eyes moved over the minuscule writing, the sword scar on his face twisted little by little.

“So that’s how it is.”

The quiet mutter slipped between his dry lips.

He stood there for a while, deep in thought, then tossed the paper into a brazier in one corner.

He watched until the oil-treated missive, prepared to keep it dry, had burned away. Then he set off for his destination.

Thud. Tap.

A dull sound echoed with each limping step.

Whenever the old man passed, those who looked like Confucian scholars lowered their heads slightly.

“Welcome, Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.”

“I have a brief report on what happened in Guangxi.”

“We’ve received an urgent message from the Namgung Family.”

“And from Hebei, Liaoning, and Shaanxi…”

Some passed with their arms full of bamboo slips; others offered only a brief greeting before moving on. Most, however, brought the old man new information. With each report, he sorted and refined his thoughts.

At last, he stopped before a firmly shut door.

Click.

The door opened as though someone had been waiting for him.

But the old man wasn’t surprised.

Just as he knew the details of events thousands, even tens of thousands, of li[3468] away, the master of this room knew what happened around him.

There was a resemblance, though the scale of their abilities was entirely different.

The old man had countless eyes and ears. The man inside could sense everything

[3468] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 m or 0.311 mi; three hundred li is about 150 km or 93 mi.

happening within a radius of over a hundred zhang[3469] by his own power alone.

“Were you practicing martial arts?”

At the old man’s first words as he entered the exceedingly plain room, the man sitting cross-legged opened his eyes.

“I was. Until just now.”

“I’m sorry. It seems I interrupted you without meaning to.”

“Don’t worry about it. I’m sure you had good reason.”

The man smiled gently. He was young.

He looked barely thirty, and the compact muscles of his bare upper body were perfectly balanced.

Of course, once he put on his clothes, he looked like any ordinary young man.

“So, what is it?”

He continued to speak to the old man with the easy familiarity of a senior.

But he had more than enough standing and years behind him to do so.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was one of the greatest pillars supporting the Murim.

“I’ve come because there’s something I must report to the Alliance Leader at once.”

“Something you must report immediately.”

The smile faded from Mae Jonghak’s lips. He took his seat and tilted a teapot as he went on.

“Is it about Shanxi?”

Trickle.

Before the cold tea had even filled the cup, steam rose from it. The old man sat down across from Mae Jonghak and ran a hand over the teacup, heated by Samadhi True Fire.

“Yes.”

The cup was warm. The news to come would be cold and dark.

Mae Jonghak could see it in the old man’s face.

“Tell me, Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion.”

The old man—Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox—answered.

“The Jin Family of Taiyuan has called off its retreat.”

“Go on.”

“All of Shanxi Murim is mobilizing. Some thirty sects and families have gathered around the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and the Shanxi Provincial Office is mobilizing every available troop.”

“Hmm.”

Mae Jonghak let out a low hum.

He hardly needed to hear more.

[3469] A Chinese *zhang* is approximately 3.33 m or 10.9 ft.

This was an all-out war. Not just Shanxi Murim, but all of Shanxi Province would live or die by the coming battle.

“What forces does Shanxi have?”

“First, more than five thousand martial artists are standing by, led by the Jin Family of Taiyuan. In addition, the government has ten thousand troops, including a thousand cavalry.”

Fifteen thousand in all.

They had scraped together every last man.

They wouldn’t even have managed to gather five thousand martial artists if the Jin Family of Taiyuan hadn’t accomplished an extraordinary resurgence over the past two years.

But the greatest problem was…

“Not even half the enemy’s numbers.”

At Mae Jonghak’s mutter, the Thousand-Faced Fox nodded grimly.

According to the Hidden Shadow Pavilion’s intelligence, the grassland army marching south would swell to at least thirty thousand, perhaps as many as forty thousand.

Because it bordered the grasslands, the government troops stationed in Shanxi Province were highly capable. But the wave of cavalry, more than twice their total strength, was a nightmare in itself.

“They seem to intend to evacuate the north first and fight in the central region to minimize casualties.”

“The central region. Taiyuan, their stronghold?”

“More precisely, they appear to be planning a decisive battle at Jeongyang, about three hundred li[3470] from Taiyuan.”

“Jeongyang. Jeongyang…”

Mae Jonghak murmured the name, then suddenly realized why it sounded familiar.

“That’s where Eight Spring Gorge is.”

“Yes.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox continued calmly.

“Eight Spring Gorge is a natural fortress. During the Great Faction War, the Demonic Cult’s great army was successfully repelled there. Two years ago, it also played a decisive part in the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s victory.”

Eight Spring Gorge lay on the boundary between central and northern Shanxi Province. It was shaped like a jar.

[3470] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 m or 0.311 mi; three hundred li is about 150 km or 93 mi.

The path was steep and the entrance narrow, making it an ideal battlefield for a small force facing a larger one.

And considering that most of the enemy forces were cavalry, it would be hard to find a better location.

The problem was that those cavalry numbered in the tens of thousands—and the true enemy had yet to show its face.

“If the decisive battle is fought at Eight Spring Gorge, what chance do you give the Jin Family of Taiyuan?”

“Even at the most generous estimate, twenty percent. No matter how much the battle turns in the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s favor, anything higher than that would be difficult.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox’s answer was firm, his gaze darkening.

“If the enemy army consisted only of nomads, I’d put their chances above fifty percent. But…”

“Right. We can’t forget them.”

Dark Heaven.

Pitch-black clouds had swallowed even the blue skies over the grasslands. Their presence alone held everyone fast, like a trap around their ankles.

“As things stand, we can’t expect to send the Jin Family of Taiyuan any support.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox’s face was dark as he said it.

As the Murim Alliance Leader’s right hand and the head of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, he was one of the people who understood the current state of the world better than anyone.

“Everyone knows what could happen if we move rashly. We could be caught in their dark arts and suffer a terrible blow.”

It defied common sense, but Dark Heaven had already used the dark art known as the Moving Formation several times.

Shaolin, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim, had suffered devastating losses because of it. The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families were no less vulnerable.

Not even here in Henan, where the Murim Alliance’s headquarters was located.

“Then the forces we can mobilize right now…”

“None.”

“None?”

Mae Jonghak gazed steadily at the Thousand-Faced Fox, who had answered without a moment’s hesitation.

“I want to ask you one thing. Think carefully before you answer.”

“Ask.”

“When you say we have no troops to send to Shanxi, is that the absolute truth?”

"…"

The Thousand-Faced Fox chose silence.

He had lived a life worthy of his epithet.

Hiding his identity and telling brazen lies as though they were the truth came as naturally to him as breathing.

But even he could not bring himself to lie under the clear gaze of Sword Saint Mae Jonghak.

"You know as well, Alliance Leader…"

The Thousand-Faced Fox spoke at last, his voice heavy.

"The balance of power has tipped too far. Helping Shanxi now would be a poor decision. You should formally order the Jin Family of Taiyuan to retreat at once."

"I think it's too late."

"It isn't. Time is short, but if we pull the front line back to Henan without delay, we can preserve our remaining forces and plan for what comes next."

"No. It's definitely too late."

Mae Jonghak shook his head slightly.

"Too late to change their minds."

"…!"

"The Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan is an astute man. He takes a broad view of every situation and is exceedingly careful before making a decision. Isn't that why you recommended him to the Murim Alliance's strategy division?"

The Thousand-Faced Fox let out a quiet hum before he could stop himself.

If a man that cautious had staked his family's fate on a decision, he would never take it back.

Not even on the Murim Alliance Leader's orders.

"But if this continues, we could lose Shanxi. We could lose them all."

"I know. If they retreat now, the innocent commoners who haven't managed to flee will be massacred by the enemy."

"…!"

"Don't turn your eyes away. They aren't fighting only to protect the homes where they grew up."

At a loss for words, the Thousand-Faced Fox closed his eyes, unable to meet Mae Jonghak's gaze.

Yes.

He knew. He had only pretended not to.

This was not a battle. It was a war.

To win it, a few thousand martial artists mattered more than a hundred thousand people.

"Was my judgment…wrong?"

"No. It was excellent. You're a better strategist than anyone I know."

At the unexpected answer, the Thousand-Faced Fox opened his eyes.

Mae Jonghak was looking at him with a gentle smile.

"You simply forgot one thing."

"What was it?"

"You were so busy looking at the whole forest that you missed a small branch within it."

At that very moment—

Srrk.

With a motion of Mae Jonghak's hand, a surge of qi reached out and flung open the firmly shut door.

Then, with the faint stir of a hidden presence, a figure swept in like the wind.

"What news have you brought?"

At Mae Jonghak's question, as if he had been expecting the arrival, a messenger from the Alliance Leader's Office bowed low and answered.

"Urgent news! The Hebei Peng Family, the Murong Family, Huashan, and the Zhongnan Sect are each sending two thousand reinforcements to save Shanxi Province—"

The Thousand-Faced Fox froze. He heard nothing more.

They were sending that many reinforcements when their own strongholds might be in danger?

It went against every principle of warfare he had learned. Against plain common sense.

But…

So that's what it was.

The Thousand-Faced Fox smiled bitterly.

Only after the messenger, bearing news he could hardly believe, had left did he break the long silence.

"I understand now. I know the name of the branch I failed to see."

"What is it?"

"Chivalry."

Mae Jonghak smiled gently.

He remembered his younger self, who had sworn to build chivalry through martial arts.

"Never forget again. We're all martial artists."

That day, with the Double Ninth Festival[3471] four days away, two thousand martial artists left the Murim Alliance headquarters and headed north.

[3471] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Chapter 951

Whoosh…

The sudden downpour sent everything into a flurry of activity.

Birds folded their wings and hurried into the grass. Beasts that had been prowling for food settled inside caves far from human footsteps.

Anything to keep warm beneath the heavy rain that fell without pause.

But the animals that inhabited this vast stretch of grassland would soon realize something: for once, the rain they had never welcomed had saved them from an unseen danger.

Rumble. Rrrumble.

A sudden vibration.

The earth shook. No—it felt as though the entire grassland was trembling.

Hidden in their shelters, the animals instinctively bristled. With the senses they had been born with—their noses, their ears, their eyes—they detected what was coming.

Beyond the rain, so dense they could barely see an inch ahead, countless riders crossed their land.

Splash! Thududududu!

Mud sprayed in every direction. Hooves trampled through puddles of standing water as the horses charged forcefully onward.

At the head of the enormous, seemingly endless column, two men stood out.

“It doesn’t look like it’s going to let up.”

The lean man muttered as he gazed at the sky, then turned to the hulking man riding beside him.

“Temur.”

At the sudden call, Temur flinched.

“Y-yes?”

“We should pick up the pace. If we delay, the whole area will turn into a quagmire.”

“Yes. I suppose so.”

Temur nodded, his voice hoarse. The lean man frowned.

“And?”

“Hm?”

“Is that all?”

“Oh.”

Temur blinked, then realized his mistake. He beckoned, and dozens of cavalrymen armed with bows and lances came galloping over. They bowed their heads.

“What is it, Khan Temur?”

“Tell every commander of a thousand under me: no rest until the rain stops. We move at full speed.”

Temur did his best to sound stern. With a sidelong glance at the lean man, he added, “Anyone who neglects this order will be severely punished in my name and that of Khan Chinggen here.”

“Yes, sir!”

The cavalrymen saluted and scattered in every direction.

Only then did the furrow between Chinggen’s brows ease.

“Good. That’s how it should be. Well done.”

Temur swallowed dryly and nodded.

“Thanks for the praise.”

“Now it’s time for you to do your part as a khan. I can’t stand beside you and give you every little piece of advice forever, can I? Right, my proud brother?”

Tap.

Chinggen patted his armor. Temur gave a start.

“You must be cold. Are you all right?”

“…Of course. Nothing’s wrong.”

“No. I know what’s in your heart better than anyone, brother.”

Chinggen let out a quiet sigh, then suddenly clenched his teeth.

“Those filthy, despicable bastards. Every one I capture, I’ll tear to pieces and throw to the eagles.”

Chinggen’s voice rang through the rain. The nomads racing silently around them, their eyes fixed ahead, flashed killing intent in their eyes beneath their helmets.

Everyone on the grasslands knew of the massacre that had taken place that day.

Temur and Chinggen.

The two young khans had seized the eastern grasslands in a single stroke, bringing peace and prosperity. Each had brought a hundred trusted retainers to their meeting.

Neither had dreamed that the ger[3472] filled with laughter would soon be stained with blood.

“Who could have known those damned Han Chinese were plotting something so terrible?”

The uninvited guests, several hundred strong, had been Han Chinese from the Central Plains—people known as Murim martial artists.

They had burst in at the height of the feast and swung their weapons at anyone in reach.

[3472] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the Eurasian steppe.

By the grace of heaven, the two khans had survived. But after a fierce battle, most of their retainers lay in pools of blood.

“My dear brother. If Tengri hadn’t watched over us, the eastern grasslands would have been torn apart in an instant and fallen into the hands of those Han Chinese.”

Chinggen gripped his reins until his knuckles turned white.

“It’s obvious what they were after. They must have judged that we’d become a threat, with each of us commanding a powerful force. At last, they’ve shown the ambition they’d kept hidden.”

At the cold look in Chinggen’s eyes, Temur answered in a voice rough as iron.

“I—I think so too.”

“It wasn’t just us. Everyone on this land was being used by them from the very beginning. Those despicable bastards were planning to seize the entire grassland all along.”

The nomads listening to Chinggen’s seething voice nodded as one.

He was right. The Han Chinese had always been like that.

Since time immemorial, they had called the nomads barbarians, scorned them, and considered them worth less than beasts.

Even after their great ancestors had trampled the Central Plains beneath countless hooves and built a vast empire, that had not changed.

No—their contempt had become hatred.

All because a mere band of barbarians had sullied the history of the continent.

But human beings were creatures of forgetfulness.

As the years passed and their ancestors’ achievements faded from memory, the nomads began to want something new.

Peace instead of conquest.

Gold and silver instead of horse manure.

Perhaps that was why everyone had welcomed Temur and Chinggen with open arms when the two promising young men of the Golden Clan joined forces with the Han Chinese.

“It was my mistake.”

Chinggen lamented as the rain poured down on him.

“I should have thought more deeply about what kind of people they were and why they’d agreed to work with us. Noble warriors of the grasslands died because their leader was ignorant and foolish.”

At the sight of his grief and regret, everyone lowered their heads.

Then a calm, powerful voice spoke.

“If you correct that mistake, the warriors of the grasslands will be welcomed into Tengri’s embrace.”

Chinggen's eyes widened at the sight of a middle-aged man with the distinctive braided hairstyle of the nomads.

"Why is Khan Jamukha here? You should be in the rear…"

"Greetings, Khan Jamukha!"

Cries rose all around them, beginning with Chinggen.

The middle-aged man, Jamukha, swept his gaze over the riders. There was a force in his eyes that none of them could resist.

"It was dull staying in the rear. I thought this old man might be of some help, so I came to see."

His sideburns were as black as night, and his imposing build was sturdier than that of a young man in his prime.

But that was only how he looked. Jamukha was well over eighty years old.

He was the greatest warrior on the grasslands, another khan who had ruled the western grasslands for many years. He had joined the army with more than twenty thousand tribespeople, and in practice, he led this immense force.

"Old man? Who would dare think that of you? Isn't that right, Temur?"

Temur gazed at Jamukha with trembling eyes, then hurriedly nodded.

"Y-yes."

"Khan Jamukha is our elder in the Golden Clan, a great warrior and a khan. We're grateful that you entrusted us with the vanguard."

Chinggen raised his voice so everyone around them could hear.

"Those foolish Han Chinese probably never knew how strong Khan Jamukha was—not even as they were dying."

Chinggen needn't have said a word. The eyes fixed on Jamukha were already full of admiration and reverence.

Jamukha, the greatest warrior on the grasslands.

According to the story, several hundred Han Chinese had attacked him before they attacked Temur and Chinggen.

He had only a dozen or so personal guards with him.

But the outcome had been staggering.

Jamukha had proved his prowess beyond doubt.

With a mere handful of guards—barely a match for the enemy numbers—he had fought a battle against the Han Chinese that was little short of a massacre.

In the end, the Han Chinese plot against the western grasslands had failed. Enraged, Jamukha had led his tribes toward the Central Plains.

Just as he was doing now.

"It was nothing. My men were simply skilled."

Jamukha answered calmly and jerked his chin over his shoulder. His personal guards, clad in dark armor, galloped after him with expressionless faces.

They were the elite warriors created by the great conqueror who had laid the foundations of the nomadic empire in the distant past.

Known as the *Keshik*, they still followed Jamukha as remnants of the Golden Clan.

Each was as strong as a warrior who represented an entire tribe.

And there were a thousand of them.

The grassland army numbered tens of thousands. Its confidence in victory was not based on hope alone.

“From here on, some of my personal guards will take the vanguard.”

“The Keshik…?”

“Yes. Is there a problem?”

Chinggen fell silent for a moment at Jamukha’s unexpected words, then shook his head.

“Of course not. We would have asked you ourselves. Isn’t that right, Temur?”

“…That’s right. I agree.”

The strongest warriors would lead the charge.

It was a natural decision, and everyone accepted it.

Everyone but one person.

Are you sure that’s wise?

At the sudden Sound Transmission in his ear, Jamukha’s lips moved.

Didn’t you just say you would have asked me yourself?

That was…

I won’t change my mind. We’ll put those children in the vanguard and cross the border in the shortest time possible.

There could be a trap. The place is crawling with fodder to take arrows for us. Why waste precious forces?

What trap? Fire King and Jin Taekyung, who won’t reach Shanxi Province for several days? Or those insignificant Shanxi fools?

Jamukha answered bluntly and stared straight at the source of the Sound Transmission.

Keep that idiot beside you under control. I’m beginning to regret not killing him back then.

I told you we should have kept the smarter one alive instead.

Chinggen—or someone wearing his face—let out a chuckle too faint for anyone to notice and ran a hand over his features.

He was impressive in his own way. Even while his men were dying all around him, he tried to negotiate.

He remembered it clearly.

Beside Temur, who had yielded to the overwhelming difference in strength and even wet himself, Chinggen had stood firm and told them to name what they wanted.

Compared to that dead man, this idiot…

I kept him alive because he's an idiot. Someone who's surrendered deep in his heart is that much easier to handle.

I'll grant you that. Thanks to his cooperation, far more barbarians gathered than I expected.

His amused gaze swept across the vast army filling the grasslands.

Only a little more than a day's travel remained.

When the rain stopped, they would cross the grasslands and go over the walls.

Chapter 952

The Double Ninth Festival[3473] was one of the continent's biggest holidays.

It came when swallows flew south to warmer lands and snakes and frogs burrowed underground to prepare for winter.

At this time of year, people climbed mountains, drank chrysanthemum wine, recited poetry, and enjoyed the scenery.

Commoners who lived from one day's wages to the next did it. So did high officials who wanted for nothing, and martial artists who lived in the turbulent martial world.

"Do you remember?"

A voice sounded suddenly behind him.

The young man gazing at the field of bright yellow chrysanthemums showed no surprise. He had known who was there for some time.

"Remember what?"

Jin Mukyung asked without taking his eyes off the flowers. A familiar presence came to stand beside him.

"Five years ago, when the three of us climbed the hill behind the house and spent the Double Ninth Festival[3474] together. We had such a wonderful time."

"…You mean the Double Ninth Festival[3475] ten years ago?"

Jin Wikyung looked hurt at his younger brother's doubtful response.

"Goodness. You don't even remember anymore?"

"I remember. I asked because your version sounds quite different from mine."

"Different?"

"Taekyung, that reckless fool, got completely drunk and caused a scene. It wasn't exactly a pleasant time."

Jin Wikyung tilted his head.

"Really? You looked like you were enjoying yourself when you beat him with your scabbard."

"I wasn't smiling. I was disciplining my own flesh and blood to set him on the right path."

"Then why were you grinning from ear to ear?"

Jin Mukyung fell silent.

Come to think of it, perhaps he had been smiling.

[3473] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.
[3474] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.
[3475] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

His youngest brother was always causing trouble, and their eldest brother doted on him. When an excuse to punish Taekyung finally presented itself, how could Mukyung not smile?

Of course, that was long ago. Only a small fragment of the day remained in his memory.

“The youngest bawled like the sky had fallen, and you didn’t touch your food. You just started training. You went off into the woods, away from everyone, and swung your sword until sunset. I can still picture you as clearly as if it were yesterday.”

“I don’t remember that, but I’m sure I did.”

Jin Mukyung’s reply was matter-of-fact.

Training was a matter of course for him. He had held a sword since childhood and practiced wherever he was, whenever he could.

Five years ago, the last time the three brothers of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had spent the Double Ninth Festival[3476] together, Mukyung had already reached the Peak realm, though he was barely twenty.

“I still remember the day you left home.”

“Ah.”

Jin Mukyung smacked his lips. He remembered Wikyung coming to see him off with a swollen face, as though he had spent the previous night crying.

“Do you… do you really have to go?”

“Yes. I really do.”

“Even if your older brother begs you to stay?”

“Not a chance.”

“What’s so special about Heaven’s Gate Temple that you’d abandon your family and go all the way to a distant land?”

“Even disciples of the great sects wait years to get into that Heaven’s Gate Temple you’re dismissing.”

“All right. If that’s what you want, I’ll escort you to Henan myself.”

“…You’re serious?”

“There’s something I need to tell the Hall Master in person.”

“What on earth would you tell him?”

“Just a few important precautions he absolutely needs to know. Some foods you hate, your habits… Mukyung! Where are you going, Mukyung!”

He had run. With every last bit of strength he had.

It was the first time in his life he had put so much effort into his movement technique.

[3476] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Jin Mukyung had only wanted to grow stronger at Heaven's Gate Temple. He'd never had the slightest intention of earning the distinction of being its shortest-lived expelled cadet.

"I still remember your back as you left, covering your eyes with your sleeve to hide your sobs."

"…"

Jin Mukyung quietly closed his mouth.

Some truths were more beautiful left untold. That he had raised his sleeve to shield his eyes from the dust, for instance. Or that he had run to escape his overzealous brother.

Before he knew it, a quiet laugh escaped him.

"Why are you laughing?"

"It's nothing. Just…"

Jin Mukyung managed to stop laughing and turned his head.

There was the face he remembered from about two years ago, when he had left once more to enter seclusion with no end in sight. Wikyung had watched him go with worry in his eyes.

Just as he was looking at him now.

"I laughed because I'm glad to see you. You haven't changed at all, older brother."

"Mukyung, you…"

"I'm glad everything is still the same."

He had spent a little over two years in pitch-black darkness.

He had kept hunger at bay with bitter, astringent fasting pills and quenched his thirst with dew and rainwater collected in the training hall deep inside the cave.

And whenever he swung his sword until he collapsed from exhaustion, sprawled on the cold ground, a thought would come to him.

Where was this place? Who was he?

If he ever left that darkness, what would be waiting for him?

"Part of me was afraid, too. Afraid that the world I knew, the people I knew, would have changed beyond recognition."

He had been half right and half wrong.

Everything around him had changed. The people he knew had not.

Surely that included his troublemaking youngest brother, wherever he was now.

"The day that brat left the family, he came to see me and said something."

Mukyung had turned their conversation over in his mind thousands of times. No, tens of thousands. Taekyung's voice, unusually calm that day, still lingered in his ears.

"See you later."

It had not been a simple farewell.

The Star-Array Grand Banquet.

Taekyung had challenged him to meet there, among the countless stars from the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes[3477] and the Four Seas and Five Lakes[3478], and test their skills alongside Cheongpung.

As brothers born of the same mother. As martial artists.

After Taekyung left, Mukyung had stood staring at the empty space he had occupied and murmured the answer he had failed to give him.

Yeah. See you later. I promise.

But that promise had never been kept.

In that place, where he could not even feel time passing, Jin Mukyung swung his sword without rest. He slashed, stabbed, and tore through what lay beyond the pitch-black darkness.

Whenever he opened his eyes to something new, another wall rose before him.

He had to get over it. Break through it.

With the unkept promise tucked away in a corner of his heart, Jin Mukyung pressed on.

Until he found a faint light in the darkness.

Until that light grew as clear as the sun.

At last, he came back into the world.

He left behind the darkness that had enveloped him for two years and emerged into a world filled with another kind.

"Hyung."[3479]

Jin Mukyung called softly and looked his own flesh and blood straight in the eyes.

There was light in his gaze, and a directness that made it impossible to lie to him.

"Now tell me what I must do."

"…!"

"No. Give me an order, as the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

For a moment, Jin Wikyung's eyes trembled.

"You knew…?"

Jin Mukyung nodded.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan now stood at the head of Shanxi Murim. With the Family Head missing, Jin Wikyung led them all as its Alliance Leader.

Shanxi Province was already at war.

Li Feng, a lay disciple of Huashan and Shanxi Province's Assistant Military Commissioner, had mobilized every force at the Shanxi Provincial Office to

[3477] The Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes is a literary expression for the whole world, from its settled regions to its farthest reaches.

[3478] The Four Seas and Five Lakes is a traditional expression for lands far and wide.

[3479] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

evacuate the people in the north. Some five thousand martial artists had gathered in the central region.

Every moment mattered.

Wikyung had not come looking for him solely to reunite with the brother who had emerged from seclusion after two years.

“Just as you know me well, hyung,[3480] I know you.”

“This will be a dangerous mission.”

“I don’t mind.”

Jin Mukyung went on calmly.

“I learned martial arts because I loved the sword. But I wanted to grow stronger for our family.”

Only great strength could restore a fallen martial family.

His sword had carried more than a passion for martial arts all these years.

“Jin Mukyung, Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. I will devote myself to carrying out the Lesser Family Head’s orders.”

His younger brother cupped his hands in a salute, his voice unwavering. Jin Wikyung slowly closed his eyes.

After a brief hesitation, he opened them again. He was no longer speaking as Mukyung’s older brother, but as the Alliance Leader of Shanxi Murim and the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“From this moment on, you are neither the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan nor the Lesser Family Head’s younger brother.”

He released the breath he had been holding.

Then Wikyung looked calmly at his brother—no, his retainer—and continued.

“I command Jin Mukyung, Commander of the Heaven Shaking Squad.”

Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword.

About five years ago, a young prodigy from the frontier had reached the Peak realm at barely twenty and earned a new epithet. His only older brother had named a fighting force after it.

He had hoped Mukyung would one day return to this place.

And with the wish that, just like the two characters in Heaven Shaking, his name would one day resound beyond the world and reach the heavens.

“The enemy vanguard that invaded the north has split off some of its troops and is taking a detour to avoid Jeongyang. Take two hundred men from the Heaven Shaking Squad and blunt their vanguard.”

Jin Mukyung smiled.

“As you command.”

[3480] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

The next day.

The vast steppe army entered the north without resistance. What awaited it was not chrysanthemums but dark-red blood covering the mountain slopes—and one terrified survivor of its vanguard.

“K-Khan…”

Jamukha stared silently at the man trembling like a leaf.

He knew at once that the thousand-man vanguard sent into Shanxi Province half a day ahead of the main force had been wiped out. The lone surviving fool had been sent back with a warning for the invaders.

“H-he told me to give you this, Khan…”

Slide. Thump.

The cloth slipped from his trembling fingers. The head of a Keshik centurion rolled out of the blood-soaked bundle.

Jamukha looked down at it in silence.

“Is that all?”

“He left a message. A message…”

His queue[3481] had come loose, and terror filled his face.

“He said, ‘Even five years from now, my brothers and I will climb the mountain together and spend the Double Ninth Festival[3482]—‘”

“Bullshit.”

Shhk.

Jamukha struck without a moment’s hesitation. The man’s severed head rolled into the chrysanthemum field.

As Jamukha gazed at the flowers, now so red their original color was gone, Chinggen smacked his lips.

“Why not hear the rest? We don’t even know who he was.”

“Does that matter?”

The thousand-man vanguard had been annihilated.

No. What mattered was that all hundred Keshik among them had died in a single battle.

“Either way… we’ll meet soon enough.”

Jamukha stared south, his voice low.

At that moment, a thought suddenly crossed his mind.

This war was supposed to be overwhelming and one-sided. It might not be as easy as he had imagined.

[3481] A *queue* is a hairstyle in which the hair is gathered into a long braid.

[3482] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Chapter 953

When dozens or hundreds of people fought tangled together, it was a battle.

But when the numbers grew to thousands, tens of thousands, it could no longer be called a battle.

It was war.

A war in which both sides threw everything they had into the fight.

And Jin Wikyung had no intention of staking everything he had on a single gamble.

“Jin Mukyung, Commander of the Heaven Shaking Squad, reporting to the Lesser Family Head.”

His voice was calm, though his whole body was soaked in blood.

Mukyung had left at noon and returned only around midnight. He looked like a blood demon.

So did his men, whose squad took its name from his epithet, the Heaven Shaking Sword.

But their proud strides and bright, fierce eyes were proof of the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s first victory.

“By your command, we broke the enemy’s vanguard and returned.”

Mukyung went on with his report.

Of the slightly more than two hundred men in the Heaven Shaking Squad, twenty-three had died and thirty-seven had suffered injuries, serious or minor.

Several of the senior leaders grew somber at the news. In a single battle, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had lost sixty men from an elite force it had devoted itself to raising alongside the Jin Dragon Squad. But the rest of Mukyung’s report swept even that brief sorrow away.

A thousand.

They had annihilated an enemy vanguard five times their number.

And among them had been a hundred of the enemy’s elite troops.

“Waaaah!”

Everyone who had been listening in tense silence cheered at once.

Their first victory against the enemy.

An overwhelming victory, beyond any dispute.

Yet even as excitement surged around him, Jin Wikyung kept his composure.

This is only the beginning.

He knew it.

War was like building a sandcastle. You had to scoop up sand and pile it on, again and again, before it was complete.

And even a sandcastle built with such care could collapse from a single hard kick.

But if we build it solidly enough to withstand that kick, it's another story.

Fortunately, the Jin Family of Taiyuan's preparations had been thorough despite the little time they'd had.

By now, the grassland army—likely crossing the Great Wall and passing through northern Shanxi Province—must have been bewildered.

First, by the news that its vanguard, which included its finest troops, had been wiped out.

And then by finding the north truly *empty*.

You won't find a thing to take there.

It wasn't only the people who had left the north.

Wikyung had withdrawn all the troops and commoners and ordered every field, though harvest was near, burned.

A scorched-earth strategy.

Against an army of tens of thousands, it was an excellent tactic. Even so, Wikyung had agonized over the decision dozens of times—until Assistant Military Commissioner Li Feng of Shanxi Province and several hundred others came to him of their own accord.

"We have several tens of thousands of seok[3483] of provisions in reserve. We can more than handle their food supply."

With Zhu Bao and Hong Jin absent, Li Feng was effectively the highest-ranking official at the Shanxi Provincial Office. He promised his full cooperation.

"Just burn the whole damn lot."

The people of the north who had been forced to leave their homes overnight—or rather, their village headmen—were already half blind with rage.

"Those damn bastards. They come raiding and raising hell all the time, and now they want to take what's growing in our fields, too?"

"Everyone in our village has already agreed. If even one grain of rice gets into those barbarian bastards' mouths, I'll be torn to pieces."

"I'd sooner feed rice to the cows and pigs. I won't stand for those bastards eating it, even when I'm dead!"

"Shit. If anyone objects, step forward now. I don't care who you are—open your mouth and I'll take you for a barbarian, shave your head, and give you a queue.[3484]"

"Hey, Mr. Song! Why aren't you saying anything? You got honey spread over your fields?"

[3483] A *seok* is a traditional Korean measure of grain, roughly 180 L (48 US gal), though its size varied by period.

[3484] A queue is a hairstyle with the front of the head shaved and the remaining hair braided, associated with Manchu rule in China.

Mr. Song, the village headman who had said nothing at all, earned everyone's applause with a single suggestion.

"Don't just set fires. Let's poison the wells."

"…!"

"It'd be even better if we took a dump and pissed in the stream before we left."

"What's the shit and piss for?"

"It'll dirty the water. You think those bastards will be fine after gulping down water mixed with shit and piss?"

"Good heavens! How did you come up with a plan like that…?"

"I tried it once. Drank about half a gallon. Thought I was going to die."

Mr. Song, a farmer with the unusual distinction of having drunk sewage, became a hero overnight. As people shoved poisonous weeds into the wells and shat and pissed by the streams, they wondered why he hadn't placed first in the civil service exams.

All while saying that the only good barbarian was a dead one—words that would have shocked someone if they'd heard them.

The road here won't be easy.

Jin Wikyung smiled coldly.

Shanxi Province was undeniably a frontier.

It produced plenty of grain, but it was neither as developed as the Central Plains nor as strong militarily.

Yet that was why its people could unite all the more fiercely in a crisis.

Long years of raids by mounted bandits and nomads had instilled a stubborn resolve in the people of Shanxi. Now that resolve had caught fire.

We will protect it. No matter what.

Wikyung had already made up his mind.

He had gone without sleep or rest to devote himself to the preparations. He sent swift-footed subordinates to watch the north and organized small detachments to look for any enemy forces that might split off from the main army.

He had ordered traps and iron caltrops set along every detour except Jeongyang. Checking the progress of the work himself was part of that effort.

"How is the earthen fort coming along?"

"With the reinforcement work included, it should be finished within half a day at the latest."

Eight Spring Gorge.

At the far end of the vase-shaped gorge, which had swallowed countless lives from the Great Faction War to the present day, stood five towers where none had stood before.

Built of mud, wood, and stone, each rose three *jang*[3485] high. Each had a level platform large enough to hold a little over two hundred people.

Two hundred archers, to be exact.

“Taking the heights above the gorge isn’t enough. These forts are essential to victory. Please do everything you can to make sure they don’t collapse.”

“Of course, sir.”

The old carpenter answered in a folksy drawl.

Even as the two spoke, countless people around them went about their assigned tasks.

They came from all walks of life.

Martial artists in uniforms bearing the names of their sects hauled weapons and heavy materials without pause. Government troops in official uniforms moved at their officers’ commands.

But Wikyung’s gaze settled on another group, people dressed in all sorts of clothes with no affiliation to mark them, working just as hard.

“Pull on three!”

“One, twooo!”

“Hyaah!”

Men covered in dust kept up the grueling labor, sweat pouring off them.

“Where should we put these arrows?”

“Oil! Bring the oil over here!”

Women carried supplies for the battle and prepared simple food.

Looking at the thousands of commoners, Wikyung felt a tightness in his chest.

I told them to flee as far away as they could.

He had warned them sincerely, again and again. He had tried to persuade them.

This wasn’t merely a dispute among martial artists.

It was a brutal war that would claim countless lives, and they, with no strength to defend themselves, would suffer the most.

But they had made up their minds and refused to leave.

They had even come to help here, on a battlefield that would soon be swept by bloodshed.

Like the old carpenter standing before him.

“Looks like our Lesser Family Head has a lot on his mind.”

The old carpenter, who had been glancing sideways at Jin Wikyung, chuckled.

He had passed seventy several years ago. When he laughed, air whistled through the gaps between the few teeth he had left.

[3485] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft); three *jang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

“Don’t you worry about it. This old man and all those folks out there came prepared.”

“But still… how could I not worry?”

“Goodness, please don’t speak so formally to me. I may be an old man without much time left, but I’m not shameless enough to expect honorifics from the Lesser Family Head.”

The old carpenter hurriedly waved his hands. Warmth shone in his pale gray eyes as he looked at Wikyung.

“Even a beast that can’t speak will repay a kindness someday. How could people turn their backs at a time like this?”

“What do you mean…?”

“When I was young and full of life, you’d have thought the country was falling apart. The Demonic Cult, or demons, or whatever those wretches were, stirred up trouble everywhere. Then came years of famine.”

It had happened long ago, before Jin Wikyung was born.

But the old carpenter remembered it clearly: boiling leather to eat and stripping bark from trees to chew.

Everyone was starving. There was no one they could ask for help, and no one able to give it.

If a group of men hadn’t come to their village one day under the blazing sun, he and his family would have starved to death before long.

“Is this Hong Family Village?”

“Y-yes, it is. What brings you here…?”

“Phew. Thank goodness we found the right place.”

What was the point of tilling fields that yielded not a single grain?

They had abandoned the barren land long before, gone into the mountains, and become slash-and-burn farmers.

So at first, they had thought the newcomers were bandits.

Or men sent by someone powerful to squeeze the last drops from people who had neither an iron coin nor a handful of grain left.

Why else would anyone come this deep into the mountains?

But instead of drawing the swords at their waists, the men set down the loads on their backs.

They were huge sacks.

Dozens of them, filled to the brim with grain and meat—the kind of sight they could barely remember ever seeing.

“W-what in the world is this…?”

“Get in line. We’ll hand it out in order.”

It felt like a dream.

It still felt like one when everyone in the village lined up as the men instructed, and when he watched his wife and children, who had lain weak and helpless for days, eat until their bellies were full to bursting.

Only after staring at that unbelievable sight and swallowing a mouthful of warm meat broth did he realize it was real.

So he cried.

No—everyone cried.

They wept aloud even as they chewed and swallowed the food in their mouths.

Because they wanted to live. Because they wanted to know they were alive.

"If they hadn't helped us that day, this old man and my family would have starved to death there."

The old carpenter looked at Wikyung with tears in his eyes. Unlike back then, he had a broad smile on his face.

"But those good people tried to leave without a word. So I grabbed one of them by the leg and hung on."

He couldn't read, not even the writing on their clothes.

So he'd clung on stubbornly, asking where they were from and begging them to tell him their three-character names.[3486]

After a long struggle, he got the answer he wanted.

"From that day on, I vowed that if the Jin Family of Taiyuan ever needed me, I would give this worthless life of mine."

"…!"

"And I'm not the only one. Every person here has received help from the Jin Family of Taiyuan, large or small."

Some of those who had received that kindness had left. Others had stayed.

And those who stayed were ready to lay down their lives.

To protect the land where their fathers and mothers had lived, where they themselves had lived.

For the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who had reached out to them when they lay exhausted, waiting to die.

That was the Jin Family of Taiyuan's true strength. It was what had sustained a distinguished family through three hundred years of rises and falls.

Ah.

Wikyung felt an ache deep in his chest.

Perhaps he was the one who had underestimated the Jin Family of Taiyuan—and Shanxi Province—most of all.

He turned away to hide his reddened eyes.

[3486] Traditionally, a Korean full name often consists of a one-character family name and a two-character given name.

Thududududu!

Hooves pounded fiercely, their sound clear even from far away.

A fine horse raced across the gorge as though something were chasing it. Hanging from the horse was a martial artist of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, dead with his eyes wide open.

"…!"

"…!"

The air froze in an instant. Jin Wikyung shouted as if spitting blood.

"Everyone, prepare for battle!"

They were here.

Chapter 954

When the sun sank toward the western mountains and darkness settled over the land, the quiet world carried sounds on the wind that no one could hear by day.

The cries of insects. Leaves brushing against one another.

And, from hundreds of *jang*[3487] away, something like a shout from someone whose voice carried internal energy.

“I don’t know who that bastard is, but he’s got a set of lungs on him. Don’t you think?”

At the low voice that pierced his ears, Temur swallowed nervously.

In his trembling eyes was the reflection of a man smiling beneath the faint moonlight.

Chinggen.

His blood relative, who had grown up alongside him since a childhood now hazy in his memory.

They hadn’t been born to the same parents, but Chinggen was a cousin closer than any brother, and a sworn brother bound to him by the anda oath.[3488]

And… a dead man. Someone who no longer belonged to this world.

This is no time to laugh and chatter, Temur.

The memory flashed before Temur’s eyes: Chinggen speaking to him with a worried look, just before an unusually cold steppe wind pushed open the entrance to the ger.[3489]

Brother, I’m sorry. You were right.

Temur lowered his head in misery.

Why hadn’t he listened to Chinggen?

Even before that day—the day of a tragedy that made him shudder just to remember it—Chinggen had sent word through messengers several times.

Something was wrong on the grasslands.

Something unknown seemed to be starting beyond their reach.

But Temur had let the warnings go in one ear and out the other. He’d filled his ger[3490] with rare treasures brought along the trade routes, then feasted on meat and liquor with his men.

He’d never dreamed what would come of it.

“What’s got you so lost in thought this time, brother?”

[3487] A Korean *jang* is about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3488] An *anda* is a sworn brother in Mongolian tradition; the oath binds two people as brothers.

[3489] A *ger* is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomads on the Mongolian steppe.

[3490] A *ger* is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomads on the Mongolian steppe.

The Chinggen of his memory vanished. Temur jerked his head up like a man startled awake and answered in a trembling voice.

To the man who had killed Chinggen—and had now become Chinggen.

“Nothing. It’s nothing.”

“Goodness. You must be nervous before the battle. Is that why you didn’t hear me?”

“What do you mean…?”

“That shout just now. Don’t you recognize the voice?”

Only then did Temur understand. He answered quickly.

“Y-yes. The Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan. It has to be him.”

“Ah, I see. I thought I’d heard that voice before.”

Of course, the man was lying to keep anyone nearby from growing suspicious. Temur might be simple, but the meticulous Chinggen would never have forgotten someone important whom he’d met several times.

“Jin Wikyung… So that’s who it is.”

Chinggen smacked his lips in satisfaction and glanced over his shoulder. At the look he gave him, Jamukha, riding with his customary calm, nodded slightly.

The Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan has more than a loud voice. He has nerve, too.

Their Sound Transmission passed discreetly through the darkness. A faint smile touched Jamukha’s lips.

If he’d meant to flee from the start, he wouldn’t have gone to the trouble of pulling that stunt.

It was quite a stunt. It cost us more than we expected.

Chinggen frowned and spat phlegm from his swaying saddle.

The Great Wall, which a cruel emperor had built across a full ten thousand *li*[3491] after unifying the continent long ago, hardly deserved to be called a wall.

Yet the north, which should have been unoccupied, was littered with obstacles everywhere.

Losing the vanguard was one thing. I didn’t expect them to turn the whole place into such a filthy shitshow.

A shitshow. Chinggen couldn’t think of a better word for it.

Northern Shanxi Province, which they had reached through wind and rain, had been devastated. Paddies and fields that should have been nearing harvest were ruined. Wells and streams were fouled with poison and filth. Even the houses had been reduced to ashes.

Those lunatics. They burned down the places they’d been living in until recently, then left.

[3491] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

At Chinggen's Sound Transmission, Jamukha's lips moved, his expression still calm.

Do you know Emperor Gaozu of Han?

I've heard of him. Liu Bang, from the story of Xiang Yu and Liu Bang?

Yes. Even the eventual victor was once driven back by Xiang Yu and had to leave for Hanzhong. On the advice of his strategist Zhang Liang, he burned the plank roads behind him.

He cut off his own way back.

But he returned to the Central Plains, defeated Xiang Yu, and became ruler of all under Heaven. This land is their plank road. As long as its people survive, they can always rebuild it.

One person alone was an individual. Ten made a group.

But gather a hundred or a thousand, and villages and cities arose.

People were what mattered.

Though everything in the north had been destroyed, those who burned their own homes must have made a vow as they left. They would return and reclaim this land. Just as their ancestors had done long ago, they would begin again amid the ruins, even with nothing left.

Of course, it's all a vain hope.

Jamukha smiled faintly.

Xiang Yu had been arrogant and foolish. Despite possessing the martial might and forces to look down on all under Heaven, he had ultimately lost to Liu Bang.

Jamukha was different.

For decades, he had strengthened his hold on the western grasslands and built up his forces, waiting for that person to call him.

And at last…

The time has come.

Jamukha gazed into the pitch-black darkness. There, where even the moonlight was dimmed by dark clouds, he could almost see the enemy holding their spears and swords upright, struggling to master their trembling hearts.

"Can you feel it? Their fear."

His low voice rang through the darkness. Charged with internal energy, it reached every ear clearly, and his eyes shone fiercely.

"Our enemies have spent their lives hiding behind tall walls. They're no different from cows and pigs—softened by peace, doing nothing but eating!"

What of the grasslands?

[3492] A *ger* is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomads on the Mongolian steppe.

Their people had been born of grass and earth. They had endured the cold north wind in gers,[3492] not behind walls, and ridden through snowy fields to hunt wild beasts.

To the nomads, death came cheap. Plunder and killing were taken for granted.

"They don't know where we came from! They don't know what great conquerors our ancestors were!"

His forceful voice pressed down upon the night air.

It was as if the sound of their ancestors' hooves, trampling across lands covered in frost and ice and crossing the dreadful, scorching desert, were faintly echoing in everyone's ears.

"Keep your eyes sharp as you draw your bows! Thrust your spears like a tiger's claws! Cut through their flesh with crescent sabers like an eagle's talons, then trample them beneath your horses' hooves!"

A light slowly kindled in the nomads' slack eyes.

They had marched without rest for more than half a month, through traps laid on every side. Thousands had lost horses they treasured as much as their own lives to poisoned iron caltrops. Thousands more had collapsed after drinking fouled water.

And that wasn't all.

With the houses burned down, they'd had to sleep outdoors beneath the night dew and fill their bellies with tough jerky made while sitting in the saddle, all to keep up their speed.

It didn't matter.

Thousands of men and horses had fallen, but tens of thousands remained. If they crushed an enemy less than half their number—if they won this battle—it would all be over.

Beyond the gorge, shrouded in darkness, more than weak enemies awaited them.

Wealth. Honor. A new age.

"My beloved brothers, remember our ancestors! Remember the grasslands in all their former glory!"

Jamukha cried out like a king of the beasts that ruled the grasslands. Like one of the great conquerors of old, who had ridden out from their gers[3493] and shaken the continent with thunderous hoofbeats.

Then he fixed his eyes on the gorge, now only a hundred or so *jang*[3494] ahead, and spoke in a low, clear voice.

"Now, it's time to conquer."

At that moment—

Clang-clang-clang-clang!

[3493] A *ger* is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomads on the Mongolian steppe.

[3494] A Korean *jang* is about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

A wave of steel swallowed the darkness. Gently curved crescent sabers, sharp lances, and arrows nocked to bowstrings in a flash gleamed on every side.

“Waaaaah!”

A roar shattered the deep night and seemed to shake heaven and earth.

Thududududu!

Dozens became hundreds. Hundreds became thousands. At last, tens of thousands swept toward the gorge like the wind.

They cried out in strange voices that chilled anyone who heard them, their hair streaming behind them like horses’ tails with every jolt of the ride. They drove forward with all their might to avenge a tragedy stained by lies and claim the glory their ancestors had once won.

Rrrrummmble!

Beyond the gorge, the people waiting there felt the fierce vibration through their bodies, as if an earthquake had struck.

“So it comes to this, after all.”

Jin Wikyung murmured, then looked down at his hand. It was clenched around his sword hilt, and it had begun to tremble.

Why?

Was he afraid of the enemy bearing down on them with such overwhelming momentum?

No.

He feared the countless allies who would die here. He feared that he would not be able to protect them all.

That’s why… we have to win.

He had taken every measure he could. There was no undoing any of it, and no retreating now.

Do everything within your power, then leave the rest to Heaven.

The old saying came to him suddenly. So did someone who hated it more than anyone—someone who wasn’t here.

No. If you’re just going to leave it to Heaven in the end, why go through all that hell? You’ve got to make Heaven change its mind, even if you have to raise all kinds of hell to do it.

Yes, that was exactly what the guy would have said.

At the sound of that voice, so vivid in his ears, Jin Wikyung let out a quiet laugh before he knew it.

Then, the next moment, he realized his hand had stopped trembling.

“Wipeng.”

At the low call that cut through the thunder of approaching hooves, his longtime loyal retainer answered.

"Your orders, my lord."

Tens of thousands of men and horses would be upon them in moments. Ragged breaths sounded all around.

Every eye turned to Jin Wikyung, their commander-in-chief. Then he said the last thing anyone expected.

"I think we should spend next year's Double Ninth Festival[3495] on Mount Heng."

"…!"

"All of us together. We'll drink chrysanthemum wine, make music, and enjoy ourselves."

"M-my lord."

"Why? Don't you like the sound of it?"

Wipeng and the others stared at Wikyung's faint smile. Then, as if by agreement, they smiled just like him, holding back the emotion rising in their chests.

Next year's Double Ninth Festival.[3496] All of us together.

Those few words stirred something deep within them.

As they smiled, their fear faded. When they laughed aloud, the stiffness left their bodies. The darkness surrounding them no longer felt so ominous.

Step.

A footfall sounded with startling clarity. Someone stepped out in front of them and spoke.

"Next year's Double Ninth Festival[3497] sounds rather enjoyable."

Jin Mukyung was smiling.

Amid the vibration and shouts that had swallowed the gorge.

In the darkness that had been his only friend for the past two years.

And in the next moment—

Thudududu—whoosh!

He turned toward the dozens of men and horses bursting from the pitch-black darkness, as though a curtain had been drawn aside.

Shing!

A dazzling flash rose from his waist and cleaved through the faint moonlight.

[3495] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month. Traditions include climbing to high places and drinking chrysanthemum wine.

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[3497] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month. Traditions include climbing to high places and drinking chrysanthemum wine.

Chapter 955

Tap.

Something cold touched me, and my eyes flew open.

My body moved on instinct, too.

Whoosh!

My fist cut through empty air.

As my vision snapped back into focus, the Bow Saint—watching me from the tree across from us—spoke with a calm expression.

“Looks like you had a nightmare.”

Ah.

Only then did I realize I’d been asleep—so deeply that I hadn’t even noticed myself drifting off.

And, just as the Bow Saint had said, everything I’d seen and experienced in it had been the worst of the worst.

“How long was I asleep?”

I asked as I tried to steady my ragged breathing. The Bow Saint dropped lightly from the branch and answered.

“Let’s see. About one *shichen*[3498].”

“One *shichen*[3499]…”

“Sleep a little longer. At least until daybreak.”

Dawn was still dim.

Above us, the morning dew that had woken me was slowly rolling down a leaf, and now and then the only sound in the deserted mountain woods was the chirping of insects.

“Old—no, where’s Master?”

“Hunting. We’ve had nothing but jerky and water for more than seven days and nights. It’s the least he can do. And…”

The Bow Saint tossed a dry twig onto the dying campfire.

“You needn’t worry about what to call him. I’ve already guessed the general situation. You two are surprisingly sentimental for such rough-looking men.”

“How did you—”

“If you have the energy to ask about every little thing, come warm yourself by the fire.”

After a moment’s hesitation, I got up and started walking.

Not toward the campfire, but toward the still-dark woods.

[3498] A *shichen* is a traditional unit of time lasting about two hours.

[3499] A *shichen* is a traditional unit of time lasting about two hours.

“Where are you going?”

“I’ll go on ahead, slowly. When Old Master gets back, we can—”

“You really are a stubborn brat.”

The Bow Saint clicked her tongue and reached out.

Fwish!

Finger Qi shot toward me with a sound like tearing wind and grazed the back of my neck. Its chilling whistle drove away every trace of sleepiness.

“…What are you doing?”

“A beating is the best medicine for a disobedient child. Sit by the fire while I’m still asking nicely. Or lie down and go back to sleep.”

I’d forgotten. The woman who looked barely thirty was still a Murim martial artist, and force came more naturally to her than words.

And the Three Saints were, among other things, a top-tier corporation—no, a nationwide gang.

I glared at her in silence, then said, “I have to go.”

“Of course you do.”

“I mean right now.”

“And I mean a little later.”

“So that’s how you’re going to play it?”

“If I do, what will you do about it?”

She answered calmly, poking at the fire.

“I was like you once. I struggled with everything I had to save even one person. I risked my life to shave off a few moments.”

“Not anymore?”

“Who knows.”

There was something hollow in her answer.

She watched the fire slowly come back to life, lost in thought as though remembering long ago. Then she spoke.

“I’ve learned one small thing.”

“What’s that?”

“That my impatience was driving me further into danger.”

“…”

“I gave every moment my best, but the results still fell short. There wasn’t even time to sit back and enjoy a meal or a cup of tea. I had to kill people and watch others die. Even after I discovered the inner demon that had taken root deep in my heart, that didn’t change.”

The eyes she fixed on the campfire glowed red, like the flames of the wars she had witnessed so many times long ago.

“I don’t like the word ‘fate.‘ If everything happens as it was always going to, no matter how hard we struggle, then what does our struggle mean? But…”

Crackle. Fwoosh.

The fire swelled as it came back to life. Beyond the drifting sparks, the Bow Saint looked at me, her gaze deep and steady.

“If something can’t be stopped even by someone who’s run without rest for seven whole days and nights… Then yes. That, surely, is fate.”

I gritted my teeth.

And I felt my body, drenched in exhaustion like a waterlogged cotton rag.

I knew she was right.

To me, *fate* was the shittiest word in the world. Even so, there were times when I had no choice but to admit it existed.

I was only human, after all. Not an all-knowing, all-powerful god.

“I had a dream. A nightmare.”

The cracked voice that came from my mouth sounded like someone else’s. My back had been damp from the moment I woke—not with morning dew, but with cold sweat.

“When I finally got there… everyone was dead. Every last one of them. Not a single exception.”

“Is that so?”

My voice trembled. The Bow Saint’s remained calm.

“You must have been terribly sad.”

I shook my head.

It wasn’t sadness. It was despair—despair that seemed to punch through the earth and plunge deep beneath it.

Even now that I was awake, I could still see them before me, all of them horribly dead.

“That’s why I have to go. Before it’s too late. As soon as possible.”

At first, I’d thought this was just a game. Nothing more than data made by bespectacled developers in black turtlenecks or plaid shirts.

But before long, I’d learned the truth. This was another world, and the people in it were individuals with feelings and wills of their own.

So I’d opened my heart to them.

To the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who firmly believed I was his own flesh and blood. To the young gate guard who’d picked a fight with me the moment we met, looking at me like he couldn’t stand the sight of me.

And to the deranged old man who’d wandered the world searching for the Disciple who remained his final regret and lingering attachment.

The sincerity they’d shown me had gathered in my heart until it overflowed.

Another friend and comrade. A Master and family.

When I closed my eyes, the faces and names of everyone I'd met rose out of the darkness.

That was why I had to run, even if it meant wringing every last bit of strength from this tired, impatient body.

Just as I have for the past seven days and nights.

I'd given it everything I had.

I'd crossed rugged mountains that even seasoned hunters avoided. Rather than waste time waiting for a boat, I'd burned through an enormous amount of internal energy to cross a river using Rising on Duckweed, Crossing Water.

That was how I'd made it here. To this place.

Only about two days to Taiyuan now.

I might already have overtaken the imperial messengers or the messenger eagles. I'd abandoned even the fine horse the Son of Heaven had given me, seeking the fastest route and running day and night without rest.

But those two short days were also enough time for the nightmare I'd had today to become reality.

I can't let that happen.

I curled my hand into a tight fist. My nails dug into my flesh, and I felt hot blood well up.

The Bow Saint had been watching me in silence. Just then, she spoke.

"Strange."

"What do you mean…?"

"You treasure them beyond measure, yet you don't trust them at all."

"…"

"Sometimes you need to trust them. They aren't as weak as you think, or so easily uprooted."

My whole body stiffened. For a moment I was at a loss for words, and then the Bow Saint's voice continued in my ear.

"Of course, you can do a great deal. You could shatter a boulder weighing ten thousand *geun*[3500] with one hand, and split a river with the other. But what if it were a mountain instead of a boulder? An ocean instead of a river? Would you just quietly bear it alone, like Yu Gong long ago?"

Yu Gong. The foolish old man who had tried to bring down a vast mountain by digging out its earth and carrying away its stones.

In the end, the Jade Emperor was moved by his devotion and helped him achieve his goal. Yu Gong hadn't done it through his own strength and effort alone.

[3500] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,000 lb).

"What if the countless people who heard Yu Gong's story hadn't laughed at him for being a fool, but had joined forces to help him?"

I didn't answer, but I thought to myself:

With their help, the old man would have achieved his goal in the end. Not through the Jade Emperor, but through the people who believed in him and followed him.

Through all of them.

Ah.

Something stirred in a corner of my heart. I looked down at my hands, smudged with dirt here and there.

As the Bow Saint had said, I had tremendous power. I could crush a huge boulder with a single punch, or split a small river for a short while with one palm.

But even that wasn't nearly enough to move a mountain or an ocean.

The same was true of the disaster looming over Shanxi Province. To clear away the dark clouds filling the sky, I needed everyone's help.

"Let me ask you something."

Her gaze was calm, yet somehow warm. She looked at me like a grandmother gently chiding her young grandson.

"Which do you believe in—Heaven or people?"

Instead of answering, I looked east, where light was slowly spreading.

Then I spoke.

"Do you happen to know what the Jade Emperor looks like?"

"What?"

"I'm a suspicious sort. I can't really put my faith in someone I haven't seen with my own eyes."

"…"

The Bow Saint blinked at my unexpected answer. Then she caught my meaning and let out a quiet laugh.

"The Daoists would be horrified if they heard you."

"That's all right. The man behind me may not be the Jade Emperor, but he's at least Yama[3501]."

Shff.

A deliberately loud footstep.

I turned and saw Yama[3502] himself—no, Jeok Cheongang—standing there with a frown.

Thump.

Jeok Cheongang set down a large deer, who knew where he'd caught it, and spoke.

[3501] Yama is a ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

[3502] Yama is a ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

"You cheeky brat. I leave for a moment, and you call me Yama[3503]?"

His tone was gruff and his brow deeply furrowed. But the corner of his mouth was twitching—a sure sign he was hiding a smile.

He'd plainly heard my conversation with the Bow Saint. Pretending otherwise, he asked, "Enough. Spare me the excuses. How about some meat for a change?"

Meat, when every second mattered.

I glanced toward the thick woods to the north, then answered with a faint smile.

"Sounds good."

I wasn't Yu Gong. I was Jin Taekyung.

And now, I trusted them. All of them.

Don't die. Not a single one of you.

I spoke the words in my heart, where none of them could hear, and sat down by the campfire.

My first proper rest in seven days and nights.

I had to save all the strength I could for the two days still ahead.

[3503]Yama is a ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

Chapter 956

Eight Spring Gorge was a little over a hundred *jang*[3504] long.

A natural gateway enclosed by cliffs some thirty *jang* high.

It was barely wide enough for thirty grown men to stand shoulder to shoulder—the worst possible place to attack. Yet there was a reason two great battles for the fate of Shanxi Province had been fought in this jar-shaped gorge.

“Break through! Trample them and keep going!”

“Brothers of the Great Steppe! Once we cross this godforsaken gorge, Shanxi Province will be ours!”

Eight Spring Gorge was the most important strategic passage in Shanxi.

It offered the quickest route through the rugged northern mountains and was the last gateway to the plains of central Shanxi.

If they took this place, positioned on the border between north and central Shanxi, nothing would remain to stop tens of thousands of cavalry charging side by side, shaking the earth beneath their hooves.

And even if something did stand in their way, they could simply trample it.

Sand and gravel could not hold back a wave.

That was precisely why the defenders had to stop the invaders before them, whatever it took.

“Hold the line! Don’t give up a single step!”

“Proud people of Shanxi! Defend your homeland from these merciless barbarians!”

“Raaaaaah!”

Screams of defiance pierced the darkness and echoed through the gorge.

Amid the dense rain of arrows the two armies loosed at each other, a single streak of light moved with graceful ease, seemingly untouched by the chaos around it.

Whoosh!

Space split apart.

The dozen or so mounted warriors charging forward with the steppe nomads’ distinctive cries suddenly felt a wind.

Not one that merely brushed past them, but a cold wind that swept through the depths of their bodies.

“…Huh?”

Their eyes widened. Their vision wavered.

And then—

Shhk.

[3504] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Eternal darkness. Light would never reach them again.

Fwoosh!

Fountains of blood surged into the air. The things that had once been people and horses were severed into pieces and flung in every direction.

They hurtled onward with all the speed of their charge—

toward the enemies they had chosen as their first targets, whom they would never reach alive.

Crunch!

Even the lightest man and horse had weighed hundreds of *geun*[3505] in life, and some nearly a thousand.

Jin Mukyung calmly looked down at the enormous chunks of flesh, caked in dirt and blood, that had carved deep furrows as they slid to his feet.

More precisely, he looked at their impossibly clean cut surfaces—and the sword in his grasp.

It really is sharp. Unbelievably so.

Admiration flickered in Jin Mukyung's eyes as he gazed at the blade, which radiated a cold, keen aura even in the dark.

Only two days earlier, he had seen what the new sword could do in battle against a thousand enemies. Yet it still astonished him.

He was a swordsman with an appetite for fine blades, after all.

I wondered what was going on when he suddenly handed me a sword I'd never seen before. If I'd refused it, I'd have regretted it for the rest of my life.

To a martial artist, a cherished weapon was his closest friend and family.

But just before Jin Mukyung's first campaign, as he was polishing his beloved sword, a sturdy old man came to see him. He dropped a long bundle of cloth in front of him and said:

"Get rid of that one. Use this from today on. I forged it for you well in advance, Second Young Master."

At first, Mukyung had thought the old man was out of his mind.

He wanted him to discard the sword he had used for over ten years? The fine blade his older brother Jin Wikyung had practically torn a pillar out of the Jin Family of Taiyuan to pay for?

But then a sword appeared between the folds of cloth. When its pure-white blade finally emerged naked from its scabbard, Jin Mukyung understood.

The mad old man before him was an extraordinary artisan, unlike any he had ever seen.

One with more than enough skill to forge a divine weapon.

[3505] A Korean *geun* is a traditional weight of 600 g (1.32 lb).

“You’ve got a good eye, judging by your face. That’s a relief. You look worthy of being its owner, at least.”

“What on earth is this…?”

“Can’t you tell? One of the finest things this old man has ever made. I worked myself to the bone on it in my old age. I forged it from something that can rival Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, so take good care of it.”

The old man had left without hesitation after saying that. Jin Mukyung remained absorbed in his new sword for a long while, until one of the family retainers finally told him who the old man was.

“Come to think of it, Second Young Master might not know. The Ironcraft Hall was newly established in our family while you were in secluded training.”

“The Ironcraft Hall? Then that old man was…”

“Yes. Hall Master Jang Taebo, head of the Ironcraft Hall. Before that, he served as Guild Leader of the Ironcraft Guild for over thirty years.”

“…!”

Even Jin Mukyung, who had devoted himself to martial arts both at the Jin Family of Taiyuan and at Heaven’s Gate Temple, knew of the Ironcraft Guild.

It was home to some of the finest artisans in the world.

They had the skill and pride to refuse to sell a weapon to anyone they deemed unworthy, even for a fortune in gold.

The retainer didn’t know why Jang Taebo, who had reigned as the guild’s greatest artisan for decades, was now at the Jin Family of Taiyuan. But there was one thing he knew for certain.

“I believe he formed a connection with the Third Young Master. So, around the time you entered secluded training, he reversed his retirement and joined our family.”

“Taekyung? That guy?”

“Yes. And somehow, Hall Master Jang brought a great many artisans who’d belonged to the Ironcraft Guild along with him. It was probably because of his old ties to them.”

But there was something neither the retainer who’d given him that information nor Jin Mukyung, fresh out of secluded training, knew.

The artisans who had dropped everything and rushed to the Jin Family of Taiyuan had not done it out of loyalty.

What had drawn even the old Master Artisans who had left their forges before Jang Taebo back to work was the final gift of a great spiritual creature that had once swum in a deep river more than ten thousand *li*[3506] away.

The Water God Dragon.

[3506] This uses the Chinese *li*, a traditional distance of approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

The imugi had never obtained a dragon pearl and so had failed to become a dragon. In the end, Dark Heaven had corrupted it. But with a young man's help, it had found eternal rest, leaving its sacred body behind.

An ingredient for working metal so rare that even a meteorite fallen from the heavens or Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron might pale in comparison—something no famous artisan could resist.

And, naturally, a considerable portion had secretly made its way to the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Its flesh and blood, steeped in spiritual power over hundreds of years, had become elixirs in their own right. Its immensely strong bones had become weapons, while its thick, sturdy tendons and muscles had become parts of armor.

Before long, parts of the Water God Dragon had found their way throughout the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Just as they were at this very moment.

Whoosh!

No matter how fine the net, it could not catch every minnow.

With their path blocked by Jin Mukyung alone, the steppe nomads had faltered at the sight of their comrades' gruesome deaths. The arrows they loosed to keep the Jin forces at bay slipped between the government troops' shields and struck a martial artist of the Jin Family of Taiyuan in the chest.

Or so it seemed for a moment.

Thunk!

Despite its powerful whistle through the air, the arrow bounced away feebly.

The martial artist, certain he had been dealt a mortal wound and about to scream, stared wide-eyed.

"Guh—huh?"

He blinked in confusion. Then he remembered the thin layer the Lesser Family Head had strictly ordered him to place over his chest beneath his martial uniform.

It was so light, with such a strange sheen, that he could not tell whether it was iron or leather.

The moment he remembered, he burst out laughing as though nothing had happened.

"You stupid barbarian bastards! Shooting like that, you couldn't hit our family dog!"

"…!"

"…!"

The nomads, who had been ready to trample the weak Han Chinese, could only look at one another in dismay.

Their bows could pierce most leather armor with ease. Now they were useless.

It was only natural for unease to spread at the thought that one of the grasslands' greatest weapons had been taken away from them.

But they soon learned that even a moment spent worrying was a luxury they could not afford.

"Now! Now's the time!"

"Loose!"

The nomads, who by then filled the gorge, heard a forceful shout from high above—from the steep cliffs rising on either side.

Another layer of darkness fell over their heads.

Shhhhhhh.

A chill sound like the rush of waves filled the air. Countless arrows blotted out even the faint moonlight as they plunged down across the entire gorge.

"E-everyone, shields—!"

The cry, almost a scream, was swallowed before it could finish.

Clang-clang-clang!

Sparks sprang from arrowheads striking the rock walls.

In the slowed world, through that brief, hazy light born of friction, they could see countless men and horses collapsing, spattering blood.

Whoosh—thud-thud-thud!

By the time they heard the arrows tearing through the air, it was too late.

The steel rain drove straight down from thirty *jang* above with more force than the nomads' composite bows could muster. It drenched the gorge in dark red blood and cries of pain.

"Raaaaagh!"

"Neigh!"

A vast tangle of screams filled the gorge, impossible to tell apart.

A nomad who had instinctively looked up rolled on the ground, clutching the arrow lodged in his eye. A steppe horse thrashed with all its might, heedless of its rider. And a lucky hundred-man commander who had saved himself with a tough leather shield breathed a sigh of relief.

Before he could finish that breath, he heard an ominous sound overhead.

Rumble. Rrrrattle.

Thunder?

No. He was wrong.

He soon saw the answer for himself.

"Ah."

A hollow sigh escaped him.

Thump.

The shield, now bristling like a porcupine, slipped from the middle-aged commander's weakened grasp. He paid it no mind.

He already knew that the shield that had saved his life could not stop the enormous things bearing down on him through the darkness.

Rrrrrumble!

Black spheres poured down the rock face out of the darkness, shaking the earth as they came.

The steel rain had scarcely stopped when the avalanche of rocks arrived. The hundred-man commander looked up at a sky where even moonlight could not reach him.

"…Tengri."[3507]

Ka-boom!

No answer came.

His sky closed over him.

"Isn't this dangerous?"

Chinggen scratched his chin as he asked. Jamukha answered without changing expression.

"How many did you send in?"

"Five or six hundred-man companies?"

Chinggen smacked his lips and added:

"Though they're gone now."

A mere half an hour.

That was all it had taken for more than five hundred troops to vanish.

And they hadn't even had a proper chance to begin fighting.

Their enemies were proving more capable than expected.

"That man's quite something."

Jamukha knew whom Chinggen meant. He nodded quietly.

"He has the makings of a Sword Demon. Like you."

"He must be the one who wiped out the vanguard, too."

"So, you want him?"

"If I asked, would you give him to me?"

Chinggen's eyes gleamed red.

[3507] Tengri is the sky deity in Mongolian and Turkic steppe traditions.

[3508] A *ger* is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomadic peoples of the steppe.

How many years had he spent in a ger[3508] reeking of horse manure? Now, catching the scent of prey for the first time in ages, he could feel his blood boil. Jamukha clicked his tongue softly.

“Still young, I see. At your age, and you still haven’t broken that habit.”

“You haven’t answered me.”

“I’ll give it to you now. No.”

“What a shame.”

Chinggen frowned, but Jamukha continued.

“No need to be disappointed. There’s prey elsewhere.”

“You mean…”

“Take the cliffs. They’re being a nuisance, so we should deal with them before any more time passes.”

“An excellent choice.”

Chinggen beamed.

Then he set off toward the prey waiting for him atop the high cliffs.

Chapter 957

The cliffs flanking Eight Spring Gorge were enormous walls in their own right.

How could they not be?

They stood more than thirty *jang*[3509] high.

Even the Great Wall, built long ago by a tyrant who unified the continent by squeezing the lifeblood out of his people, was barely three *jang* tall.

To go around the cliffs and reach this place, an army would have to spend days crossing rugged mountain ridges. To break through head-on, they would have to climb the rock face towering above them.

Of course, that wasn't impossible.

It was generally accepted that even an experienced Mountain Herb Gatherer or hunter could climb the cliffs given enough preparation and time. The uneven rock offered plenty of handholds and footholds.

But that was a different story if the thousand archers stationed atop the cliffs on either side of the gorge had no intention of welcoming visitors.

As they did now.

"AAAAAAAH!"

The nomads surged toward the cliffs like a swarm of ants, their cries somewhere between screams and battle shouts.

At that very moment, the officers, their sharp eyes fixed on the scene in the darkness below, spoke as one.

"Everyone!"

"Loose!"

Flap!

A red flag, its color barely discernible in the dark, dropped like lightning. At once, a thousand taut bowstrings were set free.

Thrum-thrum-thrum! Fwooooooosh!

The sound of waves echoed through the deep mountains.

Arrows quivered as they cut through the faint moonlight, as if they knew what awaited them at the end of their brief journey.

Clang! Thud-thud-thud!

"Gaaah!"

"No! Holrogu!"

Bodies tumbled in every direction amid the screams.

But the man watching the gruesome scene from high atop the cliff looked grim.

Even with every archer firing in a concentrated volley, we only got a hundred.

[3509] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to 3.03 m, or about 9.94 ft.

A faint, clear light shone in his eyes—a sign that he had mastered high-level martial arts and could see through the darkness below.

Their losses are smaller than expected. Even if they abandoned their horses beforehand and came prepared with shields, this is…

There was only one answer.

After a moment's thought, the man raised his baton. His adjutant, waiting with a tense expression, tied his superior's order to an arrow and shot it toward the opposite cliff.

Fwish.

The arrow traced a smooth arc, but it was still an arrow. Yet as it came whistling in, someone caught it as easily as if it had flown straight into his hand.

Tap.

The old man caught the arrow without looking, untied the missive fastened to its shaft, and handed it to an officer nearby. The armored officer quickly scanned its contents.

"Well? What does it say?"

"He says that, judging by how sharply their casualties have fallen, the enemy must have sent in their elite troops."

"That's a headache, but… it might actually work in our favor."

The old man stroked his snow-white beard.

These towering cliffs were the perfect defensive position. They were one of the main reasons Eight Spring Gorge had become a natural fortress—and why the defenders had won decisive victories in both great battles fought here.

The enemy elites sent to scale them were about to see a hellscape.

"And what else?"

"He asks our left wing to deal with the men climbing the cliffs. The right wing will keep the enemy trying to break through the gorge in check."

"Asked? By age, I may be the presiding chair, but on a battlefield like this, I follow the general's orders. Don't I?"

The officer answered with an uncertain smile.

As far as he knew, the old man before him was an astonishing master with a great reputation in Murim, while the man on the opposite cliff was his superior by far.

As a mid-ranking officer caught between them, he had no ready answer.

All he could do was follow orders and offer a cautious suggestion.

"The Assistant Military Commissioner did ask…"

"Enough, enough. It means this old man has to step in, doesn't it?"

The old man waved a hand, patted his lower back, and stood. Something dark and dull was already in his hand.

Thump.

At nearly a *jang* long, it was far too long to be a cane. And the sound it made against the rock was too heavy for wood.

What in the world is that?

Leaving the officer's unspoken question behind, the old man walked in front of the archers, who were firing without pause, and plopped himself down.

He recalled his conversation with Jin Wikyung before the battle.

"Senior, I'll need you to take charge of the cliffs."

"I owe you a debt, so of course I'll do as you ask… but this doesn't sound like you. Wouldn't I be far more useful down below?"

The old man's objection was reasonable enough.

Of the fifteen thousand troops, a thousand carefully selected archers held the cliffs and rained arrows down from above. How many enemies could possibly make it up alive? What need was there for a powerful master?

But Jin Wikyung had answered without hesitation.

"You're right. They'll think the same thing."

"…!"

"They'll climb the cliffs. They'll have to."

"You're already certain of it."

"Our allies on the ground will fight to the death with everything they have. It's only a matter of time before the enemy targets the cliffs, and their very best troops will be among those they send."

"And you want this old man to stop them?"

"If we can stop them from scaling the cliffs, we can deal them a major blow. If we hold that position to the end, we can level the scales, even though they're tipped so heavily against us."

Only then had the old man remembered something.

He had known the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan for less than a year, but in all that time, Jin Wikyung had always made the wise choice.

"Fine. I'll land you a big fish in this battle, just as you want."

"Don't push yourself too hard. I know you've recovered completely, Senior, but you still need time to recuperate…"

"Don't worry. I already owe the Jin Family of Taiyuan my life twice. This time, I'll repay that debt in full."

People of Murim did not forget gratitude and grudges.

The older they were, and the more Fame they had earned, the truer that became.

The old man was both old and renowned.

He had spent his entire life in his hometown, never joining a sect. Even after reaching the lofty realm of Supreme Peak, he had stayed there.

He'd meant to lay his bones in the place where he was born and raised.

Until the day he met a woman of extraordinary beauty and, soon afterward, lost his mind.

“At last… the time has come to repay my debt.”

The old man murmured in a low voice.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan was not the only one to whom he owed a debt. They had restored the mind that had been taken from him against his will and spent months treating his grievous injuries.

There was Dark Heaven, too.

He owed them a debt of vengeance, too.

No—he had to take revenge.

“Come on, then.”

The small-framed old man smiled faintly and gripped his beloved weapon. With a motion he had repeated countless times since childhood, he swung both arms with force.

Whoom.

His weapon—an impressive three *jang* long—whipped and bent as it scattered a dark, dull flash.

A silver-white line and hook extended from its tip, shooting toward the enemies climbing the cliff to escape the rain of arrows.

Shwaaaaa! Shhk!

White streaks tore through everything in their path.

Flesh and bone split like tofu. Dozens of severed limbs, armor and all, slid down the cliff.

Overwhelming power.

With both his martial prowess and the terrain in his favor, it seemed no enemy could evade the old man’s attack.

No—or so it seemed.

Then a red flash flickered through the dense silver net spread across the cliff.

Shhk. Shhk!

The whistle it made was fainter than the wind.

But the old man felt it clearly. The blow had severed part of the silver line that writhed like a living thing as it tore enemies apart.

And the power behind that red flash was in no way beneath his own.

Force…!

There was no doubt about it. Only power of the same kind could sever Heavenly Silkworm Thread imbued with Force in a single swing.

“How dare you!”

Shwick!

The old man roared, and his hand blurred.

His beloved weapon, imbued with strength and speed, thrashed like an imugi.[3510] The archers, sensing something was wrong, gritted their teeth and drew their bows.

“Concentrate your fire!”

“That one! The man in front is their leader! Fire together!”

Thrum! Sh-sh-sh-shhk!

Thud-thud-thud!

“Gah… urk!”

“Aaaah!”

Arrows whistled and men screamed without pause.

But nothing could stop the figure that had slipped through the mighty web of arrows covering the cliff.

Clang!

He batted away the old man’s next attack.

Whoosh!

He twisted his body, dodging dozens of arrows aimed at him from every direction as if performing an acrobatic feat.

Tap.

He stepped onto the steep cliff.

No—he blasted off it.

Ka-boom! Fwooooooosh!

He was running and flying at once.

Even a master of the Wall Lizard Technique could not have matched his speed. He charged onward in defiance of the laws that had governed the world since time immemorial.

And finally—

Tap.

The figure reached the edge of the distant cliff and faced the old man waiting for him.

Or, more precisely, with the silver flash whipping around at the old man’s fingertips.

Whoom. Shwaaaaa!

Space split apart.

Amid wind cut into dozens, then hundreds of pieces and the brilliant white glow of Force, the old man saw the figure’s face.

A gaunt build. Sharp eyes.

The man was unmistakably a nomad—and at that moment, he was smiling.

[3510] An *imugi* is a serpent-like creature in Korean folklore, often associated with dragons.

"…!"

Crack!

A section of the cliff crumbled under the tremendous force.

But there was no sign that anyone had died.

As the archers on the cliff wavered, the old man clicked his tongue and suddenly spoke to the man standing upright on empty air.

"Who are you?"

The man answered.

"A hunter."

"Then you've come to the wrong place."

"That's what I thought at first, too. But I changed my mind."

The man—Chinggen—looked at the old man and licked his lips.

"You're a little old, but you look pretty appetizing. Don't you think?"

The old man snorted.

"Third Rate hunter. You don't even know that the older you get, the tougher you are."

"That's fine. I've got strong teeth."

Chinggen bared his teeth in a grin, then asked,

"So who are you?"

"A fisherman."

The old man answered calmly, then added,

"I thought there were only minnows here. Catching an unexpected whopper has put me in a fine mood."

"That fish looks too big for an old man like you to catch."

"What can a brat like you do, no matter how hard you flop around? I'll grab you by the tail and slam you down a couple of times. That'll be the end of it."

"Oh, yeah?"

The hunter smiled at the fisherman. At that moment, the sobriquet of someone who resembled the old fisherman before him circled in his mind.

A previous-generation master who had reached great heights, yet never left the riverbank—and wielded a strange weapon.

"We'll soon see who succeeds in the hunt. Won't we, Dongting Fisherman?"

The old man, Dongting Fisherman, raised his beloved black-wood fishing rod and answered,

"Indeed. What a catch."

Shwaaa!

Two currents of wind collided head-on.

Chapter 958

Ka-boom!

A faint tremor followed the explosion.

Jamukha stroked his beard as he watched a pale cloud of dust rise from the distant cliff, visible even in the darkness.

Looks like they've started.

Jamukha knew Chinggen—or, more precisely, the person wearing Chinggen's face—well.

Cruel, savage, and strong.

No matter who he encountered up there, he would carry out his assigned task. And he would do it exceedingly well.

Clang! Krrrunch!

Flashes flickered without pause through the dust cloud, followed by more deafening crashes.

Below, the nomads had shed their armor and taken up hooks and daggers. As the archers' fire slackened, they seized the opportunity and rapidly climbed the cliffs.

"Loose!"

Fwish-fwish-fwish!

Arrows continued to fly, accompanied by occasional shouts, but that was all.

The archers' composure and accuracy had faltered. So had the dense crossfire pouring down from either side. None of it compared to what it had been moments before.

Of the thousand archers holding the two cliffs facing each other, half were already tied up by Chinggen. The other half had to keep the ground forces in check as they surged into the gorge once more.

A loosened net would eventually tear.

Jamukha intended to bring that moment a little closer.

"Mukal. Jerme."

"Yes."

"Give your orders, Khan."

At Jamukha's quiet summons, two men stepped forward.

Their clothing alone set them apart from the other nomads. Among the Keshik Jamukha had personally trained over many years, they were two of the most capable.

Following the example of the great conqueror who had once crossed the steppe and ruled the continent, Jamukha called them the Five Steeds and Five Hounds.

Five fine steeds and five loyal hounds.

The ten commanders of a hundred were outstanding leaders and fearsome warriors alike. For decades, they had served Jamukha faithfully.

Though only days ago, he had lost one of them in vain.

“There are cowards hiding up there, doing nothing but shooting arrows. What should we do?”

“We’ll break their bows, cut their throats, and return.”

“It’s close to the heavens. Tengri[3511] will be watching over us.”

The two commanders struck their studded armor with clenched fists, then turned away.

Jamukha watched them lead a hundred Keshik apiece up the cliffs, deflecting arrows as they climbed. Then he spoke again.

“Tiraun. Boorchu. Ongge.”

Three this time.

Jamukha pointed toward the gorge, where screams rang out without end.

“Your sworn brother’s killer is there.”

“…!”

“…!”

“…!”

The corners of the three men’s eyes twitched.

It wasn’t simply that they remembered their sworn brother, who had left days ago at the head of the vanguard with a hundred Keshik under his command, only for his head to return without him.

It was their pride.

Their lord was telling them to join forces and avenge the sworn brother who had died before them.

“Khan. I’m more than enough for him on my own.”

“The same goes for me, Tiraun!”

“Please send me, Ongge!”

Jamukha watched the three commanders vie to step forward.

Their bulging temples and sharp, shining eyes showed that these masters had reached the far edge of the Peak realm.

But Jamukha was both their lord and their teacher. He knew them better than anyone.

A few days ago, his subordinate’s severed head had returned instead of news of victory. Jamukha had seen the wound on its neck, leaving him no choice but to make this decision.

He’s no pushover.

[3511] Tengri is the sky deity in traditional Turkic and Mongolic belief.

Send one man, and he would never return. Send two, and only one would make it back. Send three, and they would surely return with the man's head.

That was why their eagerness to fight could not sway him.

"Go."

His voice was calm, but its chill was unmistakable.

This was an order. They could not refuse it.

Realizing there was no way to defy Jamukha, the three commanders bit their lips and turned away.

Then, like their comrades who had set off for the cliffs ahead of them, they led their Keshik forward at a run.

Hundreds of figures shot across the gorge, leaving their horses behind and vaulting over rocks and the bodies of fallen men and mounts.

Their first victims were not the Shanxi defenders, who continued to resist fiercely, but their own allies, backing away in fear.

"T-this isn't right! This isn't right!"

"Black Sheep Clan, withdraw at once! Fall back and regroup—!"

Shhk!

The old chieftain's head flew into the air.

Several hundred members of his small tribe had joined the battle at the Great Steppe's call to arms. Now, reduced to half their original number, the survivors stared wide-eyed.

"C-Chieftain!"

"How dare you!"

But dozens of spears and swords were already closing in from every direction.

Fwoooosh! Thunk!

"Guh—!"

With every flash of a blade, heads and limbs rolled across the ground.

The Keshik slaughtered a hundred or so tribespeople in moments with their lances and scimitars. The entire gorge froze at the sight.

So did someone watching from far away.

"W-what are you doing?!"

Temur's voice shook as if the ground beneath him were quaking.

But the voice and gaze that answered him were drier than the steppe's bitter wind.

"They disobeyed the Khan's orders and ordered a retreat on their own. We simply carried out the summary execution."

"B-but they're under my command—"

"That's right. They're under your command, Khan Temur."

Jamukha's next words were too quiet for anyone else to hear.

“And you, the man who commands them, are standing right beside me.”

“…!”

“Is there a problem? If you have any complaints, speak now.”

Under a pressure that seemed to grip his heart, Temur suddenly understood.

This was the limit the man before him had set for him.

Cross it even slightly, and he would not escape death either.

“N-no problem.”

“I can’t hear you very well. I must be getting old.”

“N-no problem.”

Only when Temur had forced out those words through his fear and humiliation did Jamukha nod.

“A wise choice. Military discipline must always be strict. Don’t you agree?”

Temur trembled instead of answering.

He had foreseen this when he begged for his life in front of Chinggen’s corpse, but he had tried to look away. Now that terrible future was unfolding before his eyes.

Clang-clang-clang!

Raaaagh!

From the cliffs. From the gorge.

Most of the ceaseless clashes of weapons and screams belonged to the tribespeople who had followed him into battle.

Yet as they died, those who had pledged loyalty and vengeance on the strength of a fabricated lie would never know that the two young Great Chieftains who had brought them a brief peace and prosperity had already betrayed them.

No. I’m the only traitor. I’m the one who led them to their deaths.

Temur clenched his teeth until they drew blood.

Chinggen had died with his courage intact. Temur had survived in shame.

He had fallen for the promise that if he cooperated fully, they would spare his life and let him keep his position as Khan.

No—that was just an excuse.

He had simply…

Wanted to survive. No matter what it took.

Yes. That was the only truth.

And this was the result.

Sending twenty thousand tribespeople who followed him and Chinggen ahead as arrow fodder, as human shields, to get through that dreadful gorge.

“Damn it.”

Jamukha’s brow furrowed at the mutter that slipped through Temur’s clenched teeth. Just then—

"Khan!"

A figure approached at a run, calling out urgently.

Jamukha recognized him as one of the Keshik who had headed into the gorge with the three commanders moments earlier. His gaze darkened.

More precisely, it darkened at the weapons in the man's hands.

"These are…"

A lance, a scimitar, and a bow.

Even at a glance, the three weapons gave off a cutting edge far beyond that of anything the other nomads carried. They were familiar to Jamukha.

They had been specially made as gifts for the ten commanders of a hundred who had excelled above all others among the Keshik, his personal guard.

He didn't need to ask what fate had befallen their owners.

"Did those boys go peacefully?"

The Keshik set down the weapons, now keepsakes, and bowed his head.

"They fought bravely as warriors. Surely they'll be welcomed into Tengri's embrace."

"Yes. I see."

Jamukha murmured softly.

Kill someone, and be killed by someone.

That was the inescapable fate of a warrior of the Great Steppe. The same fate awaited everyone else.

"What of the other losses?"

Everyone present understood what he meant.

Even now, dozens of nomads were bleeding and falling somewhere in the gorge, but their lives counted for nothing in his calculations.

Jamukha cared only about the losses among his personal guard.

"Though three commanders of a hundred have fallen, our overall casualties are small. Only around twenty are dead or wounded. The rest have withdrawn to the rear and await new orders."

Three commanders had died, but their troops had suffered few losses. That could mean only one thing.

Remembering the commanders' confidence that each of them was enough on his own, Jamukha let out a quiet laugh.

"They disobeyed my order."

There was no doubt those three had fought a life-and-death duel.

One at a time.

Foolish as commanders, brave as warriors.

And one by one, they must have lost their lives to the young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“Those pathetic fools.”

Jamukha silently looked down at the Keshik, who could only bow his head even lower rather than agree. Then, abruptly, he spoke.

“Order the Keshik still in the gorge to charge.”

“Khan. You mean—”

“The senior ten-man commanders will temporarily take the vacant posts of commanders of a hundred. Minimize our losses as much as possible and wear them down.”

There would be no more reinforcements.

Several other commanders of a hundred remained at Jamukha’s side, but Eight Spring Gorge was only the first hill they had to cross.

He had no intention of wasting more of his forces in this narrow gorge, or of trusting commanders who might do something foolish again.

He wanted a surer hand.

Not one of the fine steeds or loyal hounds that raced like the wind at the turn of his reins, but a vicious dog that served the same master he did.

Ka-boom!

Jamukha watched calmly as a tremendous roar shook heaven and earth. A streak of red light came hurtling toward the ground along with a section of the cliff.

Fwoosh.

The breeze felt cool as it brushed Jin Mukyung’s hair.

It was a freshness he could never have felt in the training hall deep inside the cave.

Like a reed swaying in the wind, he twisted his body smoothly.

Shwaack!

Five lances grazed his arms, legs, and waist as they passed.

Jin Mukyung reached out, and a gleaming white-silver blade slid along the steel shaft of a lance.

Shhk!

A cold slicing sound announced another death.

At the same moment, the strength and weight behind the shaft vanished.

Jin Mukyung seized the shafts that had crossed past him, grazing his body, and spun rapidly.

Krrrunch!

There were no screams. Only a thick mist of blood.

With the five lances as teeth and his own body as the turning axle, Jin Mukyung ground everything within a three-*jang*[3512] radius to pieces. When he stopped, there were no enemies left around him.

And he knew his martial prowess was not the only reason.

Ka-boom! Rrrumble!

The gorge shook.

Rocks large and small came pouring down amid a roar that seemed to split the sky. Among them, Jin Mukyung caught sight of a streak of red light bending like a living creature.

Clang!

A tremendous blow struck his sword.

As Jin Mukyung retreated, a dull ache running up to his wrist, an exuberant voice reached his ears.

“Now that’s a shame. If I’d gotten a little more used to it, I could’ve landed a whopper.”

Chinggen.

He tossed aside his black-wood fishing rod, soaked in dark red blood, and raised two swords, one long and one short. He smiled.

At his new prey.

[3512] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three *jang* is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

Chapter 959

Everything in the world had its own color, and people were no exception.

Their eyes, their expressions, the distinctive qi surrounding them—all of it revealed who they were.

The moment Jin Mukyung saw the man before him, he knew instinctively what he was.

A demon.

The two syllables flashed through his mind.

There was no mistake. The eyes drunk on killing intent. The corners of his mouth lifted in a lazy smile. The scent of blood seeping from his entire body was so strong it stung Mukyung's nose just to stand before him.

What… is this bastard?

Mukyung watched him, his gaze steady.

He could feel it in his skin. He understood it in his mind. This new enemy was nothing like an ordinary villain.

Even Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader who had once raided the Mount Heng Sword Sect and inflicted a serious internal injury on Mukyung with his unexpected martial prowess, seemed like a mere mounted bandit beside this man.

A different breed. A different class.

In the lives he had taken, and in his martial prowess.

Chinggen looked back at Mukyung and grinned.

"Just as I thought. You've got good eyes."

Step. Whish!

Chinggen took a light step, as though out for a stroll. Mukyung instantly sprang back and raised his sword at an angle.

"Your Qi Sense is useful, too."

Chinggen nodded with satisfaction.

He had let only the faintest trace of killing intent slip, yet the young man had reacted without an instant's hesitation.

Enemy though he was, Chinggen liked the young Sword Demon more than he had expected. It almost seemed a waste to treat him as mere prey.

"You're as gloomy as an old man on his last legs, but you're still just a brat… Who are you? Want to be my Disciple?"

No one had expected that. The battlefield, briefly stilled by Chinggen's arrival, stirred with alarm.

More than anyone, the hundred or so nomads groaning amid the gaps in the collapsed rocks stared wide-eyed at their Great Chieftain, doubting their own eyes and ears.

They belonged to the western grasslands ruled by Temur and Chinggen. They knew both young Great Chieftains well, which made the offer all the harder to believe.

Chinggen had become Khan through strategy and leadership rather than personal martial prowess. Yet here he was, offering to take as a Disciple the man who, through extraordinary martial skill, had single-handedly slaughtered hundreds of their brothers from the grasslands.

"K-Khan!"

"What are you saying…?!"

Cries of shock rang out from every side.

The joy they'd felt at the arrival of Chinggen and the Keshik had vanished long ago.

Chinggen smacked his lips at the sight of the nomads staring at him with wide eyes, each nursing injuries of varying severity.

"Come to think of it, this is a strange time to make the offer, isn't it? Especially with people watching."

The short sword in his left hand blurred.

Shk. Rrrrrumble!

A cold slicing sound rang out. The pile of rocks, barely holding together, collapsed onto the nomads.

Their screams as they waited for rescue were swallowed by the roar, then disappeared completely.

"Useless things. Never any help, but they sure do run their mouths."

"…!"

"Now that no one's watching, let's get back to our conversation. Hmm?"

In the sudden silence, Mukyung fixed Chinggen with a steady gaze.

"So you're Chinggen, you bastard?"

"Hey, now. Is that any way to address me?"

Chinggen clicked his tongue.

"You may be a brat, but that's no way to speak to your Master. I ought to rip your tongue out."

The swaggering manner. The ease of a man certain of his strength.

Mukyung had little trouble seeing that the man before him, wearing a nomad's distinctive hairstyle, was hiding a great many secrets.

"You've disguised yourself. Where's the real Chinggen?"

Chinggen thought for a moment.

"Who knows? Probably inside an eagle's belly by now."

"And the other one?"

"The other one? Oh, I left Temur alive. Had to keep one of them around to control the westerners."

He answered without hesitation.

The Keshik controlled everything within several dozen *jang*.[3513] Jamukha had spent years raising them as his personal guard, and they would never betray their master.

Even the fiercest hunting dog did not bite its owner.

“Well, that should satisfy your curiosity. What do you say to my generous offer?”

Chinggen was looking at Mukyung with great anticipation when—

“Impossible.”

A low voice cut in. Chinggen frowned at the face he saw over Mukyung’s shoulder.

“Impossible? Why? No, first—who the hell are you?”

The uninvited guest answered calmly.

“How could a wolf serve under a mangy dog? He’s my little brother, whom I’ve cherished like my own son. As his older brother, I can’t let that happen.”

“Little brother? Older brother?”

Chinggen’s eyes widened slightly as he looked at Jin Wikyung. Then he let out a short laugh.

“The Jin brothers… This is a much bigger catch than I expected.”

A big catch.

Wikyung’s gaze grew heavy at those words. He remembered the old fisherman who had laughed heartily before the battle and promised to bring back a big catch.

“What happened to Senior?”

He had his suspicions, but he wanted to hear it from Chinggen himself.

What had become of the Dongting Fisherman, who had willingly risked his life for the Jin Family of Taiyuan? Of the owner of that dark fishing rod lying on the ground?

His worst fears were seldom wrong.

“Oh, that old man.”

Chinggen smiled faintly.

“He was a decent fisherman, but he wasn’t strong enough. Hooked something too big for him and snapped. Just like that rod.”

“…!”

“Actually, ‘snapped’ isn’t enough. More like crushed to pieces. He was slammed more than thirty *jang*[3514] down.”

Wikyung swallowed a groan.

The black-wood fishing rod, soaked in dark red blood and cracked in several places, showed how fiercely the Dongting Fisherman had fought.

[3513] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3514] Thirty *jang* is about 91 m (300 ft).

The old fisherman had often said that when he died, he wanted his remains scattered in a blue river. Today, he had laid his bones in this gray gorge instead.

He had given his life for the Jin Family of Taiyuan, repaying the life he owed them.

Now the Jin Family owed him a debt. Him, and everyone else who had died here.

“Give me your name and title.”

“What?”

“I need to know who you are, so I can speak with my head held high when we offer a memorial rite for the dead in the future.”

Wikyung met Chinggen’s eyes with a cold gaze.

“So we can say we personally tore apart and killed the bastard who dared invade Shanxi Province and harm you all.”

“…!”

“No matter how rotten the world gets, isn’t that what people ought to do?”

Chinggen blinked his wide-open eyes, then suddenly burst into loud laughter.

“Ha! Hahahahaha!”

His laughter boomed through the gorge, pressing down on everything around it.

No—it was no longer mere sound.

Vrrrrm. Rrrrattle!

The air swelled. An immense pressure shook the ground and cliffs as though an earthquake had struck, drawing groans from all around.

“Urgh…!”

Was this what it felt like to be caught in a giant’s grasp?

The tremendous qi carried in Chinggen’s laughter made those nearby stagger. Some of the lower-level martial artists, whose internal energy was meager, went pale and coughed up blood.

“A Supreme Peak master…!”

The words slipped from someone’s lips like a groan. They gave voice to everyone’s shock.

And yet even that did not go far enough.

Just as mountain peaks differed in height, the man wearing Chinggen’s face could not be fully described by the words *Supreme Peak*.

Sssssss.

At that moment, the martial artists of Shanxi Province could hardly believe their eyes.

Fragments of broken rock were rising into the air as though suspended on invisible threads. There were a hundred or so of them.

Their jagged edges were hidden weapons in their own right, and the man standing tall at their center was nothing less than a monster.

A monster of endless change, wearing human skin.

Crack. Crrrunch!

Bone shifted and flesh compressed with sickening sounds. His appearance changed by the moment.

Everyone stared, stunned by the sight. Then three streaks of light flashed from somewhere.

Shwaaa!

The air split.

Three figures crossed the space like lightning, too fast for even the Keshik to react. As though they had planned it, all three struck at once.

Whoom. Whish!

A mighty punch and two swords blazed with brilliant light as they rushed toward Chinggen—

"How dare you!"

KABOOM!

With an enraged shout, an enormous surge of qi erupted like lava, driving everything around him away. A violent gale whipped through the gorge.

Fwooooooosh!

A thick cloud of pale dust rose, obscuring everything beyond arm's reach.

The three attackers were thrown back three *jang*[3515] by the irresistible force. They exchanged deep, steady looks—when—

Pop!

A sharp crack cut through the air, and Chinggen appeared before them.

No. Not Chinggen. Someone none of them had ever seen.

Thud.

A heavy footstep.

The old man was as bulky as two or three ordinary men put together. He wiped the sweat from his brow with his sleeve and muttered, "Damn it. I just can't get used to this."

The man who had been called Chinggen moments ago felt his own face, restored after so long, then the flesh that seemed ready to burst from his body.

Old and ugly.

That alone was unpleasant enough. Being ambushed while enduring the painful reversal of his disguise technique and Bone-Shrinking Technique had made his mood far worse.

"You ungrateful little bastard…"

The old man glared at the rats who had dared to ambush him. His eyes were so narrow and buried in fat they seemed impossible to see.

[3515] Three *jang* is about 9.1 m (30 ft).

He was furious—especially because Jin Mukyung, the first person in a long while to catch his interest, was among them.

“You dared ambush your Master? You’re expelled.”

At the old man’s declaration, Mukyung found himself wondering how his troublesome younger brother would have answered such nonsense if he were here.

Then he came up with a likely answer.

“Go suck a dog’s dick.”

“…!”

“Oh. And you’re a pig bastard, too.”

The old man’s eyes reddened with rage. Reflected in them were the two men smiling on either side of Mukyung.

“And who are you two?”

The two men, one young and one old, answered readily.

“Ghost Sword Wipeng.”

“Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek.”

At the answers of the two Peak masters representing the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Mount Heng Sword Sect, the old man licked his lips with a tongue surprisingly quick for his size.

“So, one of you’s about to die and become a ghost, and the other’s a dog from Mount Heng. Good to know.”

Shing.

Metal scraped coldly against metal. The old man crossed the two swords in his hands.

“When you reach the underworld, tell them the Demon Bird sent you.”

Those words were the signal.

The battlefield’s suspended moment ended, and the wick that had barely kept burning caught in a blood-red blaze.

Waaaaaah!

With a great roar that woke the deep night, two waves crashed into each other.

Chapter 960

The time it takes to drink a cup of tea.

That was all the time that had passed, but the Demon Bird had to admit it: he had underestimated the prey before him. No—the people of Shanxi.

“Loose!”

Fwish-fwish-fwish-fwish!

The defenders had done more than hold the cliffs.

Five earthen forts stood near the entrance to the gorge. Their ramparts of earth and stone were still incomplete, but a considerable number of archers waited atop them. At a sharp command, a rain of arrows fell on the heads of the people surging together into a single mass.

More precisely, on the steppe forces streaming toward the gorge without pause.

Fwoosh! Thud-thud-thud!

“Aaagh!”

“M-my eye! My eye!”

Screams rose on every side, and blood sprayed into the air. Nomads struck in vital spots writhed where they fell.

Several volleys followed in quick succession, opening gaps in the densely packed formation. The people of Shanxi, led by the Jin Family of Taiyuan, drove into those gaps like awls.

“Attack!”

“Waaaaah!”

Those trying to break through and those trying to stop them.

The two waves of people surged toward each other. Where they met, there would be no white foam—only red blood.

Clang! Krrrunch!

Thwack!

Steel struck steel, throwing sparks.

A nomad’s lance pierced a government soldier through the chest. A martial artist of the Jin Family of Taiyuan leaped over the soldier’s collapsing body and cut the nomad’s throat.

Shhk!

“Ghk—cough!”

Screams and groans spilled from every direction. Everyone kept killing, and everyone kept dying.

On this battlefield, there was no trace of the mercy or compassion a human being ought to possess.

The strong devoured the weak. The weak could never survive here.

That was a battlefield. And at the center of this terrible slaughter, the Demon Bird felt a pleasure he had forgotten decades ago.

“Yes! More! More!”

He laughed aloud and swung his two swords, just as he had in the days when nothing could stand in his way. He remembered the great war called the Great Faction War, when he had taken his enemies’ lives and drunk their blood to his heart’s content.

Shwaaa!

The wind split. Force surged from the long and short swords, cleaving through the air toward the most delectable prey.

“Scatter!”

Whoosh!

It all happened at almost the same instant: Jin Mukyung, at the head of the line, shouted like a thunderclap; Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng, and Wipeng, the Ghost Sword, twisted aside at his command; and—

Shhk!

The red Force barely missed them and swept away the unlucky men standing near its target.

Fwoooosh!

There were no screams. Only severed bodies and fountains of blood.

“Aah! Aaaaaah!”

Someone screamed in terror. It was the only clue to what had happened to the thirty or so government soldiers and martial artists.

In an instant, a single swing had taken dozens of lives.

No—erased them.

As though they had never existed. As though that had been their inevitable fate.

So this is a Supreme Peak master…!

A chill ran down Wipeng’s and Cheol Mubaek’s spines.

Peak and Supreme Peak. Only one character separated the names, but the wall between those realms was vast beyond measure.

If another Supreme Peak master hadn’t unexpectedly become a retainer of the Jin Family of Taiyuan about half a year earlier, they might have lost the will to fight just from seeing that attack.

But even that Senior, as powerful as he was, fell to that monster.

That was true even considering that the Dongting Fisherman had only recently recovered enough to leave his sickbed.

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek had studied under him for months. They knew better than anyone how strong he was—and what a fortuitous encounter it had been to

hear even a few words from a master of his caliber, much less spar with him so often.

The Dongting Fisherman had always been grateful to the Jin Family brothers for stopping him when he had run wild, then helping him recover. Through the goodwill he showed them, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had grown dramatically stronger.

And yet he was dead.

Killed by one man.

No—by a monster who hardly seemed human.

Now the monster who had chewed up and swallowed the old fisherman opened his jaws toward the new prey charging at him.

Even now.

Whish.

The air split with a faint sound. The instant a red flash flickered in the darkness, Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek twisted aside with all their strength.

Pipip!

Hot.

They had dodged the attack by a handspan, yet its pressure split the skin at the backs of their necks.

The sudden sting cleared their muddled thoughts.

This is…

Their eyes had widened for a moment. Now their gazes steadied.

That dodge had been no coincidence, no movement born of instinct alone. It was the result of everything they had gained from sparring with the Dongting Fisherman—their senses, their techniques, all of it.

And in half of those countless bouts, the two of them had fought together.

We can do this.

They needed only a glance to know what the other intended. Their gazes crossed for an instant, and both men blurred into motion.

Fwap!

They shot off to either side. They vaulted over friend and foe swinging blades at one another in the blood-soaked chaos, then raced along the steep rock face, throwing everything they had into evading the monster’s Force. It was faster and stronger than the Dongting Fisherman’s.

Shhk! KABOOM!

The solid cliff face, formed over what must have been hundreds of years, split like tofu. The tremendous energy that seeped into it tore everything around it to shreds, but Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek didn’t stop.

They couldn’t.

If they failed to bring down the enemy before them, everything would be over. And if they gave in to fear, or faltered at the wounds multiplying as they drew closer, how could they face the young man already ahead of them?

Second Young Master.

Heaven Shaking Sword.

They could see Jin Mukyung clearly, charging without hesitation through the ceaseless shower of Force. Flecks of blood scattered from him, but there was not the slightest tremor in his sturdy back or legs.

They found themselves wondering how he had spent those two years. How this other genius, briefly overshadowed by Jin Taekyung and Cheongpung, had lived in lightless darkness before finally emerging into the world.

And then they saw it.

Hssss.

Moonlight slid along the white blade.

No. It was a massive Sword Energy, shining brighter than either Wipeng's or Cheol Mubaek's.

Whish.

In a world that seemed to have slowed, the blue Sword Energy swept down at an angle and met the Demon Bird's red Force.

KABOOOOM!

The explosion stopped everyone in their tracks for an instant and shook the gorge.

For someone at its center, it brought joy and astonishment as well.

Rumble.

"Ha! Hahahahaha!"

Beyond the fragments of rock scattering in every direction and the cloud of dust rising thick in the air, the Demon Bird laughed like a madman and thrust out his hand like a thunderbolt.

Boom!

Compressed air burst outward, clearing his view. Jin Mukyung stood at the far end of a deep furrow a full *jang*[3516] long. The Demon Bird bared his yellow teeth.

"Well, well! What a brazen little brat!"

Powerful killing intent mingled with delight. The two swords in his hands trembled—but not just because of what he was feeling.

Tap.

He already knew what had touched his heel.

[3516] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

A rock.

A fragment of stone that had been three steps behind him just moments ago, but now touched his heel. He felt its hardness and chill through his blood-soaked leather shoes, and that was the greatest reason for his smile.

“I can’t remember the last time someone made me step back.”

The rock had not moved toward him. He had retreated.

No—he had been forced back.

A brat not yet thirty had forced back an old monster whose life had been steeped in blood since the Great Faction War.

Though the distance of three steps and a *jang*[3517] was considerable, it meant nothing to the Demon Bird. He had seen it clearly.

Just before the two different streams of Sword Energy and Force met, the beautiful path traced by the brat’s fingertips.

That light, as blue as the sea.

“Ah. So that was it.”

Squelch.

The Demon Bird stepped forward slowly, his foot sinking into a pool of blood. Blood overflowed with his heavy step, a testament to his bulk.

“I thought it strange. Even while I fought that old Dongting Fisherman, why did your face keep coming to mind when I’d never seen it?”

A few days earlier, a messenger had brought news of the vanguard’s annihilation, along with the severed head of a Keshik commander of a hundred. In the cut, the Demon Bird had seen the Sword Demon’s handiwork.

“The moment I saw it, I was interested. The work was that perfect.”

Everything leaves a trace.

Beasts, people, martial arts.

Every death has its own cause, and that is especially true for a martial artist of Murim. Looking at the chillingly smooth cut, the Demon Bird had felt blood long gone cold begin to boil.

Was it because he had found traces of a divine art believed lost long ago?

Or because he had sensed the work of someone whose strength rivaled his own?

No.

Only now did he understand why he had been unable to put the Sword Demon out of his mind, even while fighting a Supreme Peak master like the Dongting Fisherman.

“One Strike.”

He could watch it hundreds, thousands of times and find not one wasted movement.

[3517] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

Dazzling. Beautiful, even.

A perfect strike.

That single movement was what the young Sword Demon before him possessed.

He had not accumulated several *jiazi*[3518] of internal energy or mastered a divine art that could look down on the world.

It was colorless and odorless.

That was what made it more lethal than anything else.

Like the Formless Ultimate Poison, swallowing a life before its victim could react. Like an assassin approaching unseen in the dark to cut a man's throat.

"Amazing. No—extraordinary."

The Demon Bird's admiration was genuine. As he looked at Jin Mukyung, regret and sorrow entered his eyes.

"Why? Why did I have to meet someone like you now?"

Ptooey.

Jin Mukyung spat out dark red, bloody phlegm and answered evenly.

"Even if I'd met you much earlier, there's no way I'd have called a mangy pig like you my Master."

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek closed in alongside him, moving to surround the Demon Bird. The old man sighed regretfully.

Why? Why now, of all times?

If they had met a year—no, three years—later, their match might have made his whole body tremble with joy.

Only a half-collapsed wall stood before Jin Mukyung now.

That moment of joy would never come again.

Jin Mukyung wouldn't survive this place today.

"What a shame. Truly."

Hssss.

Blood-red light rose from the Demon Bird's entire body.

[3518] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

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The moment he saw the faint blood-red glow rising through the darkness, the Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, finally recognized the obese old man who had introduced himself as the Demon Bird.

“Blood Soul Fat Demon.”

The name escaped him like a groan. The Demon Bird’s face twisted.

“How does a brat like you know…?”

Cheol Mubaek would turn sixty in a few years, but even a veteran like him was little more than a green young pup in the Demon Bird’s eyes.

What bothered the old man most, though, was hearing that long-buried title again.

Blood Soul Fat Demon.

He had earned it by treating murder as a hunt. Even among the countless fiends, he had been unusually obsessed with death and blood. But the title carried mockery, too.

Fat.

That one word had always gotten under his skin, and the Demon Bird had never been one to resist his feelings or instincts.

“It’s been a long time since I heard that damned title. I’ve killed so many people for saying it that now, even when they recognize me, plenty pretend they don’t.”

He had killed the execution squads sent by the orthodox faction, the unorthodox rabble who bowed and scraped to curry favor with him, and even fiends he’d once been fairly close to.

The reason was simple.

They had called him by the title he couldn’t stand to hear.

Why else would he have named himself the Demon Bird, a title that didn’t suit his appearance in the slightest?

And now a green young pup with the unheard-of title Tiger of Mount Heng had dug up memories he’d put away.

How dare you.

Cheol Mubaek’s fate was all but sealed. The Demon Bird put his name at the top of the list of people he intended to kill, then spoke.

“A brat like you couldn’t possibly have met me before… Who was your master?”

Crack.

Cheol Mubaek clenched both fists.

“Fist Hero.”

“Fist Hero?”

The Demon Bird stopped in the middle of his unhurried approach.

He hadn't expected much when he asked. He had spent his life killing, and once the count passed a thousand, he'd stopped keeping track. There was no reason to remember them all.

But Fist Hero's title remained vivid in his memory. The man was one of the few who had survived a life-and-death duel with him.

"Well, isn't this something. You're Fist Hero's Disciple? Wait—he raised a successor with that body?"

The Demon Bird forgot his anger and burst out laughing. Cheol Mubaek answered coldly.

"Don't insult my master. He was a far greater man than you could ever be."

"Of course he was. Even after his life as a fist fighter was over, he managed to raise a Disciple. I'll give him credit for his grit. You should've seen his face when I cut off both his arms."

"…!"

"Now that I look again, this is quite a lavish feast. The young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and the successor of the Shura Annihilating Fist."

As the Demon Bird surveyed them with satisfaction, Wipeng spat.

"Can't see me?"

"Of course I can. I can already picture your corpse lying there in a moment."

"You have to see how long or short it is before you can tell."

"That's the kind of bullshit weaklings say."

Thud.

The old man's heavy, wrinkled flesh rippled as he stepped forward. His sharp gaze seemed at odds with his massive frame as he sized up the three men.

"Well, then…"

Whoosh.

"Who should I kill first?"

In a single step, the Demon Bird closed a distance of several *jang*.[3519] The two swords in his hands swept through the air in arcs.

Like the blood-red claws of a bird.

Whoooosh!

Shhk—KRRRUNCH!

A gale howled.

Mighty pressure swallowed the air and tore at their skin. Dirt and shards of rock blasted outward with a roar.

[3519] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

—Second Young Master!

Wipeng's Sound Transmission pierced Jin Mukyung's ears.

Mukyung had been retreating again and again to avoid the Demon Bird's Force. He jerked his head aside.

Whoom.

Two razor-sharp streams of wind skimmed past the back of his neck.

The two Keshik gripping crescent-shaped sabers clicked their tongues in disappointment. Mukyung had dodged their ambush as though he'd been expecting it.

That was the last anyone saw of them alive.

Shhk!

By the time the blood-red flash appeared, it was already over.

The Keshik fell quietly, never knowing how—or why—they had died.

Behind their collapsing, headless bodies stood someone who could have told them, radiating enormous killing intent.

"You dare try to steal my prey?"

CRUNCH!

Blood Soul Fat Demon. Or the Demon Bird.

The obese old man angrily trampled the fallen Keshik's bodies, as though he'd completely forgotten the other prey rushing at him from behind.

Or as though they weren't worth noticing.

"You bastard!"

The Tiger of Mount Heng, Cheol Mubaek, roared and threw a punch.

He was the Disciple of a great fist fighter who had lost both arms to a fiend long ago. He had become a protector of the Mount Heng Sword Sect to help a friend's only daughter.

Whoooooom—BANG!

Compressed air exploded. Fist Energy shot from his spinning fist and engulfed his master's killer.

Or at least, that was how it appeared for an instant.

Fwoosh!

A long sword, tinged red like its owner, sliced through the air.

The Fist Energy that had seemed ready to reduce anything in its path to ash faded and scattered. A sneer touched the Demon Bird's lips.

"You're certainly no match for your master. I'm not even sure that's the Shura Annihilating Fist I knew."

But the Demon Bird knew the truth.

Some two hundred years ago, the Shura Annihilating Fist had ranked among the ten greatest fist-and-foot arts in the world. Cheol Mubaek's current realm wasn't all that far from Fist Hero's, either.

Neither the art nor its successor fell short. The Demon Bird had simply grown stronger.

"Come!"

He felt the blood in his body boil.

The two swords in his hands had never felt lighter. Every movement his prey made looked clear—and slow.

As though reading a future that had yet to happen, he raised his blade to meet a flash thrusting in at an angle.

KABOOM!

The impact was far too loud to have come from two swords simply clashing.

Wipeng groaned as the tremendous recoil sent him flying. The Demon Bird launched his massive body after him, certain of what would come next.

One first.

Water flowed from high to low. People grew old and died. Everything in the world had its destined course.

To the Demon Bird, Wipeng's death was just as certain.

A Peak master who had reached an impressive realm for his age. An outstanding swordsman whose practical sword technique justified the title Ghost Sword.

But that was all Wipeng was.

With enough effort and luck, he might reach Supreme Peak in ten or fifteen years. That day would never come. Meeting the Demon Bird in this gorge was proof that Heaven had already abandoned him.

Those who had yet to cross the wall, and those who had.

That was the difference between Peak and Supreme Peak.

Become a ghost. Live up to your title.

Blood-red light flashed as the Demon Bird swung both swords.

The short sword in his left hand went for Cheol Mubaek, who was rushing to save his comrade. The long sword in his right went for Wipeng, who met it with all his strength.

But the clash unfolded in a way the Demon Bird hadn't expected.

CRUNCH—KRRRRANG!

"…!"

A substantial recoil traveled up both sword blades.

The Demon Bird's eyes widened at the dazzling sparks blooming where three different streams of energy met.

What?

He was more shaken than he could have imagined.

Cheol Mubaek and Wipeng—those young pups who hadn't crossed the wall, prey who should have been no more than a meal—had stopped his strike.

With nothing more than their paltry Fist Energy and Sword Energy, they were holding out against Sword Force he had unleashed with all his strength.

How?

The Demon Bird was a born killer and hunter. He knew better than anyone how far beneath him his prey stood, both in their enlightenment in martial arts and in the internal energy they held.

Yet the impossible was happening before his eyes.

A mere Peak master had met head-on the Force he'd swung with several *jiazi*[3520] of internal energy. It was something that couldn't happen—and shouldn't.

Cough. Spurt.

Blood mixed with bits of their innards poured from Cheol Mubaek's and Wipeng's split lips.

The Demon Bird stared, frozen in shock. The two men bared their bloodied teeth and smiled.

They could barely hold out against the blood-red Force. Cheol Mubaek's snow-white gauntlet and Wipeng's sword blade trembled beneath its overwhelming power.

Then the Demon Bird noticed the faint glow of their prized weapons, visible even through the thick blood, and remembered something he had briefly forgotten.

A Supreme Peak master's Force could be resisted by something other than Force of the same kind.

Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron…!

The Demon Bird caught his breath.

How could he have known? In all his long life, even he had never obtained a divine weapon like these. Yet two Peak masters from remote Shanxi Province each held one.

Nor could he have guessed that the weapons he mistook for Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron were made from the bones of a spiritual creature that had guarded a river unseen for hundreds of years.

His moment of surprise gave someone who was still standing an opening.

Hup!

Wipeng wrung out every last bit of his strength and twisted his sword.

His wrist was already broken and his hand mangled, but he swallowed the blood rising from his severe Internal Injury and turned aside the energy bearing down on him.

[3520] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

KRRRRUNCH!

The long sword slid along the snow-white blade and drove into the ground.

Deep—driven by all the force behind it.

Thud!

Anger flared in the Demon Bird's eyes as he recovered from his shock. At that very instant—

CRUNCH!

Cheol Mubaek grabbed the short sword that had been slowly forcing his gauntlet back. His hand closed around the Force shrouding its blade.

Crack. Krrrunch.

Something broke with a sickening sound, and unbearable pain followed.

The irresistible power crushed the flesh inside his gauntlet and splintered his bones. Without a divine weapon made from the Water God Dragon's bones, both his hands would have vanished without a trace the moment they touched the Force.

But Cheol Mubaek did not let go.

The pain was too great even to groan. His organs twisted under the immense energy, yet he held on to the blade with all his strength.

He remembered the great master who had taught him long ago, even without his arms.

And he waited for someone to kill the bastard in his stead, to do what he, an unworthy Disciple, could not.

At last, that wish reached someone's sword.

Shwaash.

A sound so faint it raised goose bumps.

A flash shot forward like a bolt of lightning and descended toward the Demon Bird.

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In an instant split into ever smaller fragments, the Demon Bird realized he had only one choice left.

Shwaa.

A faint whistle of displaced air approached like a ghost and brushed his ear.

At the same time, the world slowed.

Everything was clear.

The shallow breaths of Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek, both suffering severe Internal Injuries. The drops of blood spilling from between their lips.

And then the Demon Bird finally released the two beloved swords he had been gripping tightly and turned around.

He kicked off the ground with all his strength and thrust both palms forward like a bolt of lightning.

Fwoosh!

Blood-red Force flashed around his hands.

The tremendous energy, enough to reduce even a boulder weighing ten thousand *geun*[3521] to dust in an instant, surged forward without resistance.

Toward the sea-blue Sword Energy falling over the Demon Bird's head.

Toward the man who had brought that blade-sharp wave of Sword Energy crashing down.

Jin Mukyung.

The eyes of the young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan met those of an old fiend who had spent his life killing.

The two men could hardly have been less alike.

Not in the lives they had led, the eras they had been born into, or what they held in their hearts.

The young man had learned martial arts simply because he loved the sword. The old man had wielded one to kill.

The young man had wanted strength to restore his declining family.

The old man had craved strength because the stronger he became, the more people he could trample underfoot.

The young man was one of countless people who wanted no part of an age of chaos. The old man longed more than anyone for those bygone days when blood ran in rivers and corpses piled up like mountains.

The paths they had walked were different, as were the directions they would go from here.

[3521] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

Even now, the Sword Energy and palm force they hurled at each other sounded different.

Shhk.

The Sword Energy descended like a blue wave, or a single bolt of lightning, yet its sound was as faint as a child's breath.

RROOOAR!

The enormous blood-red palm force roared like thunder.

And between those small differences lay a gulf as deep and wide as all the differences that had come before.

One crushed the wind. The other cut through it.

Gooooom.

A distant flash. Air seething with heat.

As the red and blue lights raced toward each other, a thought struck the Demon Bird.

Supreme Peak and Peak.

Perhaps the wall of enlightenment between Sword Energy Becoming Force and the level of injuring others with Sword Energy was not as high or imposing as he had thought.

This is…

Even amid the raging gale, the Demon Bird could see the blue light shining clearly.

That unwavering strike, descending at an angle along its destined path, was proof of all the enlightenment the young man had gained so far—and of his progress toward a new realm.

Rumble.

At last, the two immense forces met. They erased the wind.

They warped space.

And under pressure great enough to tear his body apart, Jin Mukyung closed his eyes.

It was a deep night, with even the moonlight dim. Once his sight was cut off, pitch-black darkness settled over him.

It was so familiar. Every bit of energy and sensation in his body surged and flowed into the sword in his hand.

He could see nothing, but he could feel it.

His opponent's overwhelming power, ready to sweep everything away.

The openings in that ferocious, and therefore unstable, palm force.

Yes.

There.

As if entranced, Jin Mukyung brought his sword down. Blue light slipped between his closed eyelids, clearer than ever before.

A thousand times, ten thousand times—or dozens, hundreds of times more.

Hammer and cool it beyond counting, and even worthless scrap iron will one day become a fine sword.

A single drop of water can crack solid rock. A single thorn lodged in an elephant's foot can bring it down.

Just as it did now.

Shwaaaash.

The Demon Bird saw it clearly.

A blue flash, so sharp it looked like a single thread, split his palm force from side to side. It was unbelievable.

And he marveled.

Ah.

Speed, power, trajectory.

All of it was dazzling. So perfect it sent a shiver through him.

That sharpness could no longer be called Sword Energy. The flash of a divine weapon cut through the blood-red Force and pressed on.

Truly beautiful.

The words never left his lips. The Demon Bird smiled brightly and reached both trembling hands toward the blue streak falling over his head.

Shhk.

That beautiful, dazzling wave was cold enough to make him shudder.

The world stopped.

No—everyone in it stopped moving.

The nomads who had kept fighting, not daring to interfere in the battle of a superior who was practically a tyrant. The Shanxi defenders who had been slowly tiring against the endless waves of troops.

Even Cheol Mubaek and Wipeng, who had watched everything from closer than anyone else on the battlefield, could do no more than cling to their fading consciousness.

Shhk.

The single, startlingly clear slicing sound from moments ago still rang in their ears.

Along with a question they couldn't understand.

What on earth…?

What just happened?

The same thought crossed everyone's mind.

Red and blue had flashed within a distant, swelling blaze of light. That was all.

Everyone on the battlefield had seen that dazzling light clearly, and at the same time, no one had seen a thing.

Now, only the two men standing a *jang*[3522] apart with their backs to each other could break the silence that had settled over the narrow gorge, thick with blood and corpses.

Jin Mukyung and the Demon Bird.

The Demon Bird and Jin Mukyung.

The old fiend, who had spent long years killing countless people, and the young Sword Demon, who had spent the past two years swinging a sword in pitch-black darkness, slowly turned to face each other.

Splash.

A heavy step sent blood spilling from a puddle. No one knew whose it was.

Soon, someone's fresh blood filled the space it had left.

Cough.

Lips pressed tightly together parted. Like a cracked dam giving way, blood mixed with fragments of innards burst through the tiny gap.

Splaaash!

Dark red blood sprayed through the air and soaked the ground. Reflected in the refilled puddle was the young Sword Demon's pallid face.

"No! Mukyung!"

CLANG!

At the desperate cry from somewhere far away, the clamor of steel began again.

Thinking of the familiar voice behind that cry, Jin Mukyung smiled faintly. The Demon Bird suddenly spoke to him.

"What was that strike?"

The question was far too short to contain everything he felt and wanted to know.

Jin Mukyung swallowed another surge of blood before answering.

"I don't know either. I've never done it before."

The Demon Bird gave a wry laugh.

He wasn't mocking him. Those who stepped into a new realm in a moment of No-self, forgetting even themselves, always gave the same answer.

He had too, when he was young.

"Honest, at least."

"Can't help it. It's true."

"If only I could see that strike of yours one more time. Just once, before the end."

"I'll pass. I've seen enough of your face."

The Demon Bird's smile widened.

[3522] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“Have you named that form?”

Jin Mukyung quietly shook his head.

What he had trained was a martial art. In a sense, it wasn’t one at all.

Only One Strike.

He had spent two years searching for a single path for his sword, and today, in this place, he had glimpsed its very edge.

He had never thought to give the form a name.

Not until the old monster in front of him brought it up.

“Blue Wave, Falling Bird.”

A blue wave surges, and a bird falls.

The Demon Bird murmured it like a line of poetry, then asked Jin Mukyung with unmistakable pride, “Well? Pretty good, isn’t it?”

“Hard to say. It’s kind of cheesy.”

“Oh.”

Disappointment spread across the Demon Bird’s face. Then Jin Mukyung went on, his voice calm.

“But I suppose I could get used to it.”

“Really? I knew you’d see it my way.”

The Demon Bird grinned from ear to ear.

He had no idea faint red lines were beginning to appear all over his body.

No—he was doing his best to pretend he hadn’t noticed.

“Heaven Shaking Sword, Jin Mukyung. Of the Jin Family of Taiyuan… Cough, you young Sword Demon.”

Drip. Drip.

Blood fell in scattered drops.

The Shanxi defenders rushing to save Jin Mukyung and the steppe fighters who had held them back, certain of their superior’s victory, stared wide-eyed at the Demon Bird.

The old fiend steadied himself as he swayed, his gaze fixed on Jin Mukyung alone.

“Kill. Kill, and kill again.”

His eyes and voice burned with the obsession he had kept all his life: murder.

“With the strike that cut me down. Everything that stands in your way. Every last thing. Guh. Every last…!”

Slith.

The Demon Bird never finished.

The red lines crossing his body, and the beads of blood swelling along them, finally burst in a magnificent explosion.

FWOOSH!

A fountain of blood surged upward, staining the air.

Everyone stared in shock as the Demon Bird collapsed like a rotten tree.

One man had fallen. One still stood.

There was no mistaking the victor.

Jin Mukyung looked down at the corpse lying face-first in the pool of blood it had made, its upper body and both arms severed. Then he spoke quietly, returning the words the Demon Bird had said before the battle began.

“When you get to the afterlife, tell them a man from Shanxi killed you.”

He gripped the sword hilt, which felt heavier than ever, and without hesitation cut off his enemy’s head. He raised it for all to see.

Shhk.

“I, Jin Mukyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, have slain the Blood Soul Fat Demon!”

“…!”

“…!”

The force of his shout, carrying what little internal energy he had left, froze the air in the gorge.

Jamukha’s personal guard, already well aware of the Demon Bird’s identity, was stunned by his end. The Shanxi defenders stared wide-eyed at the title of the fiend who had stained the world with blood long ago.

The Demon Bird was dead.

And in that same moment, another Supreme Peak master had been born.

“Waaaaah!”

A tremendous roar shook the gorge. Their blood boiling like erupting lava, the Shanxi defenders charged without regard for their lives.

They looked ready to swallow the personal guard, still frozen by the unexpected turn of events, and the nomads in the rear, bewildered by the connection between their Great Chieftain Chinggen and the Blood Soul Fat Demon.

“Attack!”

“We are Shanxi! We will not fall!”

“Wipe out every barbarian who dared invade this land!”

“Loose!”

Shh-shh-shh-shshsh!

Beneath a downpour of arrows, thousands of martial artists and government troops drove like a wedge into the broken enemy line. Jin Wikyung led them, his eyes bloodshot.

“They’re coming!”

“Shields! Sh—!”

Puhpuhpuk! KRRUNCH!

The blood mist that had briefly settled rose thick again.

With the tide turned and their morale at its peak, the Shanxi defenders charged into the jaws of death.

They swung their weapons with every last ounce of strength, and endured the pain, biting at their enemies until their final breath.

Shhk! CRUNCH!

Cut one down, and two took his place. Cut two down, and three came on.

After that, there was nothing. Only death.

CRUNCH!

Seven in ten Keshik were First Rate warriors. They were unquestionably the finest troops on the grasslands. Yet the roughly three hundred deployed in the gorge were cut in half in no time.

“What do we do? What are we supposed to do now?”

The Keshik squad leader gave no answer to his subordinate’s desperate shout.

He couldn’t.

The three commanders of a hundred were dead. So was the Demon Bird, an absolute master alongside Jamukha.

And that was not all.

Even now, his men were dying to blades coming at them from every direction.

And at the center of it all was a ghost, staggering as he drank in blood without end.

Shhk. Shhk!

He brought his sword down, slashed, and thrust.

With those simple movements, Jin Mukyung felled twenty Keshik.

Despite his unmistakably severe Internal Injury, the Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan stood in the middle of the gorge, protecting his two companions.

What is this…?

The Keshik squad leader squeezed his eyes shut.

After a brief hesitation, he ordered a retreat.

Or rather, he was about to.

Then a familiar sound rang out behind him.

Boooooo!

The squad leader knew what it meant.

That great call from dozens of horns sounding at once was for one man alone.

Jamukha.

The great Khan, the supreme ruler of the grasslands.

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Boooooo!

As the horn's unintelligible call rang through the night, Jin Mukyung found himself wondering what was moving his body now: will or instinct?

Shhk!

A flash cut through the air. Another enemy fell beneath his gleaming sword.

The movements carved into his whole body through countless repetitions still traced their paths with precision, even as he staggered and bled.

Shhk, thud!

He slipped past a thrusting spear from behind and drove his sword, held in a reverse grip, into his attacker's side.

"Guh!"

The dying groan reached his ears. Mukyung pulled the sword from the man's chest and left the collapsing body behind, already rushing toward another enemy.

His eyes, impossibly, were closed.

And yet…

It's all so clear.

He could feel everything without seeing it. No—with his eyes closed, everything around him felt even more vivid.

Darkness.

He had spent two years in darkness so complete that not a single ray of light could enter. He had swung his sword to grow stronger and, at times, to keep from going mad.

As his sight dulled, his other senses sharpened beyond measure. His Qi Sense had grown by leaps and bounds.

"K-kill him!"

"He's only one man! If we take him down…!"

Crunch!

A grisly sound of torn flesh cut the shout short. Mukyung felled yet another enemy amid the endless carnage—he had lost count of how many—and steadied his ragged breathing.

He was dizzy. His body felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton, his mind as hazy as a dream.

The fight against the Demon Bird had given him more than a moment of enlightenment.

A severe Internal Injury.

His organs and acupoints were twisted and torn. He could almost hear them screaming.

Mukyung knew defeating the Demon Bird had taken something close to a miracle. Cheol Mubaek and Wipeng had risked their lives to help him. He had delivered a perfect strike, one he wasn't sure he could ever repeat. And he had wielded a divine weapon capable of standing up to Force.

If any one of those three things had gone differently, the Demon Bird would be standing here instead of him.

But…

Damn it.

Nothing came without a price.

Mukyung swallowed the blood rising in his throat and drew a breath. He closed his fingers tight once more around the hilt that kept slipping from his grasp and felt, with every sense, the enemies surrounding him. Their breathing was thick with fear and rage.

Beyond the ceaseless shouts and screams, he heard a faint voice.

"Hurry. Go on."

Jin Mukyung already knew who owned that hoarse, elderly voice.

"I'm not going. No—I can't go."

Mukyung opened his eyes. Blood running down his forehead stained his vision red, but he could see Cheol Mubaek and Wipeng, each on one knee and gasping for breath.

"We're going back. All of us."

Wipeng laughed at the resolve in his voice.

"See? What did I tell you? Those Jin Family people are stubborn as hell, h—"

Hack. Drip, drip.

He broke off and coughed up blood. Mukyung's gaze darkened.

The color of coughed-up blood, and what came with it, could tell you how bad an injury was. By that measure, it was a miracle Wipeng was still conscious.

"Damn it. After coughing up bucketfuls, now all I've got left is a handful."

He said it as though it were nothing, but Wipeng knew how dire things were. He fought to keep his eyes open and looked at Mukyung.

"Second Young Master. May I say one thing?"

"No. Don't say any more. Save what strength you—"

"Mukyung."

"…!"

Mukyung went rigid. Wipeng bared his bloodstained teeth in a smile.

"Go. Stop being so stubborn."

"…"

"I know it, Great Hero Cheol here knows it, and you know it too. You know what's best."

Mukyung clenched his teeth.

“It’s not too late. We can still go back.”

“Yes. We can go back,” Wipeng added gently.

“If you go alone.”

“What are you—!”

“Leave before it’s too late. You can still break through.”

Pushing deep into the enemy ranks to spare their allies as many casualties as possible had been the right choice. It had also been a costly mistake. Even now, hundreds of enemies surrounded them, watching for their chance to strike.

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek saw that cruel reality clearly.

The old tiger who had once commanded Mount Heng was no more. Neither was the Peak swordsman with his ghostly swordplay.

The tiger’s claws were broken. The Ghost Sword’s swordplay was gone with his shattered arm.

That was the price they had accepted to tie down, for just one moment, the hand of a fiend who had once shaken an entire age.

But…

“You, Mukyung—you, of all people, have to live.”

“Not because you’re the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek looked at Jin Mukyung through eyes that seemed ready to go dark at any moment.

The young man reflected in those eyes was no longer simply Jin Mukyung. He was the hope they had to save, even at the cost of their lives. He was the revenge that would one day return upon their enemies tens, hundreds of times over.

“Live. Survive, whatever it takes.”

“And come back. To us, and to them.”

Spring. Summer. Fall. Winter.

The four seasons returned without fail. Only people vanished as they passed.

That was why Wipeng believed, and Cheol Mubaek was certain: the winter that had come early for them today would one day reach their enemies too. The young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who would protect countless people in the years ahead, would bring them down.

“So…”

Wipeng gave Mukyung a faint smile. He remembered the young man as a boy, coming to ask him to teach him the sword.

“Leave this place at once. Jin Mukyung—no, Commander of the Heaven Shaking Squad.”

“…!”

“This is an order from your superior in the family.”

Mukyung was struck speechless. He squeezed his eyes shut.

He knew. What the best choice was. What he had to do to save more people.

But his feet would not move.

He still remembered the lesson he had learned alongside martial arts when he first picked up a sword.

Chivalry.

Stand against the strong and help the weak. Never turn away from injustice. Keep faith as dearly as life itself.

That was what it meant to be a chivalrous hero. It was the way of life a martial artist of the orthodox faction, one who stood for what was right, was supposed to follow.

He had learned martial arts because he loved the sword, because he wanted to grow stronger. But he had never forgotten the weight and meaning behind those two words.

What's best?

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek had said it, and Jin Mukyung had endlessly repeated it in his heart even as he cut down his enemies.

And suddenly, he understood.

"You're both wrong."

Shhk.

He opened his eyes and pressed his foot into the blood-soaked earth.

His sword tip, trembling a moment ago with fatigue and doubt, pointed toward the enemy without the slightest wavering.

"Before we ask what's best or worst, there's something we mustn't forget."

Shhk, shhk!

A nomad creeping closer was split diagonally through the torso. Blood ran down the snow-white blade that had cut through both the man and his spear.

"What's right?"

Mukyung moved like flowing water. The blue Sword Energy that had been fading now surged along his blade, the insight of that fleeting moment slowly finding its way into his sword.

Shwaaash!

A thick mist of blood bloomed. Mukyung cut down three Keshik with a single stroke, snatched a crescent saber from a dead man's hand, and sent it flying.

"What choice won't I regret?"

Whoosh! Thud!

A single streak of light cut through the air. At its end, death came without even a scream.

A man stringing his composite bow fell. At that signal, the enemies packed around Mukyung gave vent to their pent-up fear and rage and charged as one.

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

Fwoosh! CLANG!

Flashes gleamed in the darkness.

Jin Mukyung knocked away the throwing blades, but a dozen thrusting spears and crescent sabers came down on him.

Pit, pit!

Heat. Drops of blood mingled with the wind whipping past.

He knew he could avoid them, but his body refused. The places all over his body where blades had grazed him burned with pain.

Or perhaps what burned was his disappointment and anger at himself. For even a moment, he had thought about what was best instead of what was right.

This is the only right choice.

The turmoil in his head cleared. Mukyung clenched his teeth with all his strength.

Crack.

The stench of blood filled his mouth.

One pain drowned out another. His fading awareness returned.

And at the same time—

Tsutsutsu.

The blue Sword Energy, rippling like small waves, gathered into one. Guided by the will of the man holding the sword, its currents joined and merged, then traced a single beautiful arc.

An arc so perfect that the dead old fiend would have laughed aloud to see it.

Shwaaaash.

The wind disappeared. A chill cleaved through the darkness.

The ten Keshik squad leaders charging at Mukyung widened their eyes as one.

At last, they understood what the Demon Bird had seen in his final moments. What that monster of a martial artist had felt.

Shing.

Their spears, shining with tangible energy, groaned. So did their crescent sabers.

As the energy around each weapon faded, the ten Peak masters watched their prized weapons break into pieces. Their vision tilted.

“S-Sword Demon…”

Fwoosh!

A dense fountain of blood stained the air.

Beneath the sticky blood pouring down like a shower, Jin Mukyung had felled ten birds with a single strike, like a blue wave. He murmured softly.

"I'll keep that promise."

Blue Wave, Falling Bird.

Thinking of the old fiend who had become the first prey of that once-nameless strike, Mukyung stepped toward the enemies frozen before him.

At that very moment—

"May I hear who you made that promise to, and what you promised?"

"…!"

Mukyung's whole body went rigid.

The unfamiliar voice had come from a man standing barely ten feet away, looking at him.

"You…"

"Jamukha Khan!"

One shout—no, the same cry erupted from every direction, drowning out Mukyung's voice.

Jamukha.

The voice was unfamiliar. The name was not.

The words spoken by the strongest nomad warrior as he died—the day Jin Mukyung annihilated the thousand-man vanguard that had invaded Shanxi Province ahead of the main force—were still vivid in his mind.

He will punish you. Jamukha Khan will. He'll take everything from you and burn it—your family, your friends, your home.

Now, facing Jamukha at last, Mukyung understood. There had not been the slightest exaggeration in that curse.

"So it's you. The Sword Demon."

Jamukha.

The supreme ruler of the grasslands took a step toward Mukyung.

Rrrumble.

A faint but unmistakable tremor traveled up through everyone's feet.

Chapter 964

Rrrumble.

Ripples spread across the pool of blood that had lain still.

Tiny fragments of stone trembled. So did the countless corpses, their eyes wide open in death.

This is…

Everyone felt the tremor, small but unmistakable.

And at the same time, they knew instinctively what it meant.

An earthquake?

Ridiculous.

This tremor was undeniable proof that at least several thousand men and horses were closing in.

The cruel omen was enough to give some people hope, and others deep despair.

“Waaaaah!”

Wheeeee!

The gorge filled with shouts.

The nomads, whose morale had plummeted at the Demon Bird’s death, let out shrill cries and charged.

“Reinforcements!”

“Jamukha Khan has arrived!”

If Jin Mukyung’s defeat of the Demon Bird had turned the tide of battle, now the reverse was happening.

Jamukha.

A name unfamiliar to the people of Shanxi. The ruler of the western grasslands, the absolute master of the vast Great Steppe. As if his arrival weren’t enough, at least several thousand reinforcements had joined him.

The nomads had been pushed back, their morale dwindling like a dying ember. Now it soared. The Shanxi defenders, who had been driving back the invaders moments ago, felt their forgotten fatigue and fear return.

Even the man leading them felt it.

What do I do now? What am I supposed to do?

Jin Wikyung swallowed a groan.

Blood from his enemies ran down the commander in chief’s sword, proof of how fiercely he had fought.

He had given the battle everything he had.

He had joined the fighting himself to raise his men's spirits. Whenever a crisis arose, he had given flawless orders, sealing the gorge entrance so thoroughly that not even a drop of water could pass.

Fifteen thousand troops, scraped together from across Shanxi Province.

But reality was cold.

Less than half of those fifteen thousand could be called the main force, and even they had suffered heavy losses against the enemies who kept pouring in.

For every enemy they felled, there were two. For every two, five.

For every five, ten.

And behind them, tens of thousands more still waited.

In this long, dreadful war of attrition around the narrow gorge, it was not the rocks that would break first, but the pebbles.

Was this how it had to end?

Jin Wikyung breathed hard and looked around.

Everything was hazy, muffled.

Enemies and allies charged over heaps of corpses and tangled together. He stood rooted to the spot while a retainer called to him, but the enemy's shouts drowned out the words. They reached him only in broken snatches, like stepping-stones across a stream.

"…urry, hurry!"

He couldn't make out the words, but Jin Wikyung understood exactly what his retainer meant.

A hand tugged hard at his sleeve.

The retainer's face was full of despair and urgency.

And it wasn't just the retainer in front of him. Everyone around him—the martial artists of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, the Sect Leaders of their vassal sects, and the government troops—was speaking to him with their eyes.

You have to get out of here.

You have to live.

Yes. I suppose so.

Jin Wikyung understood how they felt.

The scales of victory and defeat had already tipped, and the invaders from the steppe were stronger than anyone had expected.

No—the strength of Dark Heaven, planted deep in the steppe, was far more terrifying than he had imagined.

Even now, the best course was to order a retreat.

While the troops at the front held out to buy time, he—the commander in chief—could gather the remaining forces and withdraw. That was the best strategy.

But…

There's no reason the commander in chief has to be me.

Jin Wikyung smiled faintly and tightened his grip on his sword hilt.

He had spent the past few years more accustomed to a brush than a sword, but the Sword Energy of a Peak master had not dulled in the slightest.

Shhk!

A Keshik trying to break through his guards crumpled without a fight.

Jin Wikyung advanced, cutting down the enemy with clean, precise movements. His retainer hurried after him again.

"Lesser Family Head, why—"

Thuk!

Jin Wikyung took another life and spoke.

"Tell Lee Seowol, the Sect Leader of the Mount Heng Sword Sect, that from this moment on, I'm leaving everything that follows to her."

"…!"

"Go. Now!"

With that shout, Jin Wikyung swept his sword through the air.

A defeated commander had nowhere to return to. After sacrificing the lives of so many of his people, this was where he belonged.

She's clever. She'll manage.

With the weight on his heart lifted, his sword felt lighter. Pain flared from the wounds where lances and arrows had grazed him, setting his blood ablaze.

I promised everyone I would protect this land—Shanxi Province.

He had made another vow, too.

Even if everyone else fled in terror, he would remain here.

He would live and die with them.

"Come on, then! I am Jin Wikyung, Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan! I'm right here!"

Crack!

At the sight of Jin Wikyung advancing with a beast's roar, a flame sprang up deep in the eyes of the Shanxi defenders who had been wavering.

A shiver, its origin unknown, raced from the crowns of their heads through their bodies.

There he is.

The man they had been searching for all this time was right there.

The man who cherished and loved this barren land and the people living on it more than anyone.

The true Alliance Leader of Shanxi Province.

"Yaaaaah!"

“Protect the Lesser Family Head! Protect Shanxi Province!”

With a tremendous roar that shook the gorge, the people of Shanxi charged with all their strength.

They did not retreat.

Not one of them.

Jin Mukyung suddenly felt fatigue seep through his whole body.

It was the pain of his flesh, which he had momentarily forgotten, and the vague helplessness of facing an insurmountable wall.

Was this how it had to end?

Jin Mukyung looked up at the sky and muttered inwardly.

Even the faint moonlight had been swallowed by the clouds. As always, the sky offered no answer.

It simply hung over everyone in silence, watching, as though this too were fate.

The countless enemies and allies.

The corpses that had left this world and could no longer move.

And the two men standing tall at the center of it all.

Jin Mukyung and Jamukha.

“That’s a fine sword. More than worthy of being called a divine weapon.”

Jamukha’s gaze moved slowly.

To the blade, shining white even in the darkness. To Jin Mukyung. And, finally, to the Demon Bird’s corpse, sprawled in a pool of blood without so much as a twitch.

“He always called himself a hunter. Arrogant and stupid, considering how long he’d lived.”

His eyes and tone were calm.

Jamukha showed not the slightest regret at the Demon Bird’s death. Jin Mukyung tightened his grip on the hilt and spoke.

“If he’d heard that, he’d have been sad. You’re saying he was a hunting dog his master didn’t even acknowledge.”

“Master?”

“He was a subordinate you cared for, wasn’t he? Or was I wrong?”

Jin Mukyung had tossed out the remark to create even the smallest opening. But Jamukha’s gaze did not waver in the slightest.

“I’m disappointed.”

“What?”

“Speak with your sword, not that tongue of yours. A provocation like that doesn’t suit someone like you.”

"…!"

"You're still far too clumsy at it. Though choosing the wrong opponent was a big part of it. Like that pathetic fool lying over there."

At Jamukha's scornful glance toward the Demon Bird's corpse, Jin Mukyung bit his lip.

Jamukha was right.

Trying to provoke an opening by using the Demon Bird's death had been the wrong move from the start.

Jin Mukyung didn't know why, but even after losing his sharpest-toothed hunting dog, Jamukha seemed entirely unmoved.

No—somehow, he even seemed pleased.

What is it? Why?

As Jin Mukyung wrestled with the question, Jamukha, who had been studying the Sword Demon with interest, suddenly spoke.

"If you're not going to swing that sword, why not put it down?"

For a moment, Jin Mukyung understood what he meant and let out a quiet laugh.

"You want me to surrender? To you, of all people?"

"Surrender?"

Jamukha frowned and shook his head.

"No. I mean submit. Roll over and show your belly to your master, wag your tail, and lick the tops of his feet like a dog."

"…!"

"You'll have to become my new hunting dog. Fortunately, I happen to have a spare collar."

Jin Mukyung stared silently at Jamukha.

Then he spoke without warning.

"The Blood Soul Fat Demon—the Demon Bird—said something similar to me."

"Did he offer to take you as his disciple?"

"I didn't listen closely. It sounded like a pig squealing. But something like that."

"That's no surprise. He would've trained you and eventually tried to kill you himself. Though, looking at how he ended up, he'd have been the one to die."

Jamukha spoke calmly, then continued.

"But don't misunderstand me. I'm not like the Demon Bird."

"You don't look any better than him. If anything, you look worse."

"I only intend to raise you as a hunting dog instead of prey. I might even let you off the leash when the time is right."

"Sure. I bet you would."

Shing.

A cold, sharp edge filled the air.

Jin Mukyung slowly raised his sword upright and spoke across its white blade.

“By the time that ‘right time’ you’re talking about comes, everything I want to protect will be gone.”

Their conversation was over. He had no regrets.

Better to die as a human being, the Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, than survive as a hunting dog.

To Jin Mukyung, who had already resolved to die, everything Jamukha had said was bullshit from beginning to end.

At least, until he heard Jamukha’s next words.

“I’ll spare your life. Yours, and all of theirs.”

“…What?”

“If you refuse to become a hunting dog because you have something to protect, then I mean to give you enough food.”

Jamukha looked at Jin Mukyung, whose eyes had widened, and gestured toward the battlefield, filled with screams and shouts.

“Do you know how to tame a hunting dog? It’s surprisingly simple.”

A leash alone was not enough.

A hunting dog that hadn’t been fully tamed would become a beast the moment its leash came off, and bite its master.

“But what if it’s starving?”

A hunting dog kept on a tight leash and starved for days on end would grow docile. It would have no strength left to bite anyone, and in the helplessness it had never experienced before, it would realize it was nothing but an animal.

“That’s when the master appears and tosses it some food.”

Shk.

Jamukha held out his hand toward Jin Mukyung.

There was nothing in his empty palm. Yet Jin Mukyung could see it clearly.

Not meat dripping with blood, but the countless people of Shanxi fighting to the death inside the gorge.

Everyone’s lives—including his own.

“…!”

Jin Mukyung gritted his teeth without realizing it.

Was it fear of the man in front of him?

Wrong.

It was hope.

Just for a little while.

The hope that if he betrayed righteousness and turned his back on chivalry for only a short time, everyone could survive.

That he could save the people continuing a blood-soaked battle whose ending was already decided, his one and only older brother, and the two Peak masters waiting to die behind him.

“Mukyung!”

“No! Absolutely not!”

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek.

Jin Mukyung looked at the two men shouting with what little strength they had left, his gaze sunk deep.

“I’m sorry. Both of you.”

“…!”

“…!”

Wipeng and Cheol Mubaek’s eyes widened. Jamukha smiled.

Jin Mukyung looked at Jamukha and parted his lips.

“Did I ever tell you?”

“Tell me what?”

“What I said to a certain pig bastard who wanted to take me as his disciple.”

Jamukha’s smile faded a little as Jin Mukyung stepped toward him.

With a single phrase, spat out through clenched teeth, he answered:

“Go suck a dick.”

“…!”

At the instant Jamukha’s expression hardened—

Booooooo!

Far away, the sound of dozens of horns blowing at once reached the gorge.

Jamukha knew better than anyone what that urgent blast meant.

An enemy attack!

And at the same time, he realized something.

The tremor everyone in the gorge had felt moments ago hadn’t come from the nomads alone.

Chapter 965

Boooo! Boooooo!

The horns sounded in wave after wave, but this was nothing like their earlier call.

Instead of joining in one great roar, the blasts broke off in fits and starts. There was urgency in them, too.

Even the people of Shanxi, who did not know exactly what the horns meant, could tell that something unexpected had happened to the enemy before them. And that this sudden turn would bring them a stroke of luck they had never imagined.

“Now! Now’s our chance!”

“Don’t fall back! Keep pressing them!”

Not one of the Shanxi defenders stopped to wonder what had happened.

Not a single one.

They had already made peace with dying. They had stayed to protect their homes, their families, and their friends, and now they faced the invaders head-on.

Those who came to take, and those who stayed to protect.

They did not share the same desperation, or the same weight of resolve.

The people of Shanxi wrung out every last bit of strength. They stumbled forward and swung weapons that felt heavier than ever.

At the enemies faltering as they grasped what the horns meant.

At the cruel invaders from the steppe.

Klang!

Thud, thud!

Sparks flew where sharp blades met.

The Keshik, frozen for a moment in confusion, scrambled to fight back. But that moment of distraction was all the furious Shanxi defenders needed.

Shhk!

Saber Force surged along a crescent saber, sending the limbs of three or four men flying. Yet even in their agony, those who had not died threw themselves at a Keshik squad leader with all the strength they had left.

“Y-you crazy bastards…!”

Crack!

Flesh split with a sickening sound. The shout stopped short.

Not many people could survive an axe buried in the crown of their head.

No. None could.

“That’s what you get for setting your sights on Shanxi Province, you damned barbarian.”

Ptooey.

An unknown martial artist spat phlegm onto the squad leader's corpse, its eyes still wide open in death. Then he carefully took the sword from the hand of a comrade who had fulfilled his final duty and closed his eyes in peace.

His voice was thick as he said goodbye.

"Rest here a little while. I'll kill just ten more and be right back."

He knew the truth.

No—all the people of Shanxi knew.

They might never come back. They might never meet again in this life.

But knowing that changed nothing.

Nothing except the resolve with which they faced certain death.

"Yaaaaah!"

A cry like a scream shook the gorge.

It broke the stillness of the deep night, pierced the blare of dozens of horns, and traveled farther and farther on.

Past grass darkened by night and ground packed hard by countless hooves, until it reached a band of horsemen cresting a high hill and racing toward the battlefield.

The towering old man at their head smiled when he heard the fierce cry rising from the people of Shanxi.

"Yes. I hear you loud and clear. This old man does—and so do we all."

Thud, thud, thud!

Pounding hooves shook the earth.

The wind drove the stench of blood deep into their nostrils. The ceaseless clangor of steel set blood that had gone cold boiling again.

"Thank you. You've held out well."

His murmur faded into the wind rushing over him.

The towering old man spoke from the heart to those who had fought without giving an inch in the worst of circumstances. To those still desperately facing an overwhelming enemy.

He offered them his respect, his gratitude, and his apology.

"We swore to stand together beneath one banner. Yet some turned away when our neighbors were in danger, afraid their own fences would come down."

His voice rang clear over the pounding hooves.

The words were a reminder of his own shame, and a rebuke to everyone riding behind him.

"Spilled water cannot be gathered again, nor can an arrow be called back once it leaves the bow. But…"

The Jin Family of Taiyuan and the people of Shanxi had not been easily broken.

They were still here, burning with countless lives as fuel.

Their cup had not yet shattered. Their enemies' arrows might still be on the string.

“Look at them. And remember this well!”

His shout rose like wildfire, tearing through the night air.

The old man pointed toward the gorge, where a fierce battle was raging.

Below the hill, the steppe army was rapidly closing in, moving toward them to the sound of horns. He paid it no heed and continued to shout.

“They are our neighbors, our friends, our comrades-in-arms! They swore beneath the same banner as we did. And they are the very people our family tried to turn its back on!”

The old man was ashamed.

Ashamed of the family that had tried to abandon the people of Shanxi. Ashamed that he himself had wavered, if only for a moment, at that pathetic proposal.

But he had not forgotten the vow they had made long ago: to rise together against the injustice of Dark Heaven and save a world sunk in misery.

That was why he had ridden here with all his strength, repeating the same hopes to himself again and again.

Hold out until the end. Let us not be too late.

The people of Shanxi had not let him down.

They had given him another chance to unfurl the banner he had been too ashamed to raise.

“What are you?”

At the old man’s roar, like the bellow of a beast, two thousand tightly shut mouths opened as one.

“Fighters!”

Fighters.

For a very long time, they had called themselves fighters, not martial artists.

To them, martial arts were not something to hone for their own sake. They were tools for battle.

“And what is an enemy to you?”

At the old man’s next shouted question, the eyes of those riding through the darkness flashed.

“Weak losers who will kneel before a fighter’s spear and blade!”

Thud, thud, thud!

Boooooo!

Thunderous hooves and blaring horns rang out one after the other.

The sight of countless horsemen charging toward them through a hazy cloud of dust, just over thirty meters[3523] away, did not shake a single one of them.

[3523] Thirty meters is about 98 ft.

They were valiant fighters. Those men were losers who would soon be broken and crushed.

“I’ll ask you one last time!”

The old man roared. The enormous saber in his hand now scattered dazzling flashes of light.

“Who are we!”

The gap closed. Watching a wave of lances glint in the darkness, the two thousand fighters shouted with one voice.

“The masters of Hebei!”

At that very moment—

Flap.

The twenty or so standard-bearers, who had waited through the past several days for this moment alone, raised their flags high.

A blue tiger that looked ready to leap to life, and four characters stitched in a rough hand, billowed fiercely in the rushing wind.

At last, they revealed themselves to everyone on the battlefield.

The Hebei Peng Family.

The Tiger of the North. One of the Five Great Families.

And the towering old man leading them was a great tiger, grown stronger still through the long years.

“Charge!”

With a roar that shook earth and sky, the old man kicked off his saddle and shot toward the enemies closing in on him.

Rrrumble.

Thunder that chilled body and mind.

The old man—no, the Thunderbolt Saber King—swept his great saber through the dense forest of spears and blades like a massive bolt of lightning.

Kaboom!

A blinding flash and a deafening boom swallowed everything around them.

Behind the old tiger, who rampaged through the enemy formation and shattered it, two thousand fighters burst through the thick haze of blood. Together they pierced the enemy ranks like a single awl.

Crack!

In the deep of night, when even the birds slept—

The battle, and the Double Ninth Festival,[3524] were not over yet.

[3524] A traditional festival held on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Everyone heard it.

And everyone saw it.

The strange thunder that had come from the ground, not the sky.

Beyond the flash and the boom, dozens of blood-soaked flags snapped in the wind as the enemy shrieked.

“The Hebei Peng Family! It’s the Hebei Peng Family!”

“T-The Thunderbolt Saber King…!”

The first was the Shanxi defenders’ cry of joy. The second was the nomads’ lament.

Peng Cheolhu, the Thunderbolt Saber King.

His name and title were no relics of a bygone age.

An old tiger might lose its strength and standing among its own, but the teeth and claws of the great tiger called the Thunderbolt Saber King had only grown sharper.

What’s more, the Hebei Peng Family was a renowned great family that ruled the north alongside the Murong Family.

In that sense, the Thunderbolt Saber King and the martial artists of Hebei following him were showing exactly how they had earned the titles of Ten Kings and one of the Five Great Families.

Boooo! Boooooo!

As the horns blared without pause, Jamukha had a sudden thought.

This is going to be a long night.

But he was not flustered.

The Shanxi defenders, united around the Jin Family of Taiyuan, had fought harder than he expected. The arrival of the Hebei Peng Family, though, was within the range of what he had anticipated.

So was the Thunderbolt Saber King himself.

“Just as that person said.”

At Jamukha’s muttered words, Jin Mukyung’s face stiffened. He had been trying to steady himself, to keep his emotions from taking hold.

“What did you just say?”

“The Thunderbolt Saber King’s temper is so fiery that he’ll act without thinking of the consequences. So even if he leads the Hebei Peng Family to Shanxi’s aid, it will be no surprise.”

Jamukha spoke without hesitation, then added quietly:

“That is what that person said. I remember it clearly.”

“…!”

“Don’t look at me like that. If you thought we couldn’t anticipate even this much, I’d be very disappointed in you.”

“W…e?”

“Yes. We.”

Jamukha nodded slightly and clicked his tongue as he looked at Jin Mukyung.

“A pity. If you’d taken my hand, you could have been one of us.”

Step.

Jamukha took a step as casually as if he were out for a stroll.

Shwack!

The crescent saber in his hand sliced through the air.

The strike was so precise and swift it made Jin Mukyung’s skin crawl. His eyes widened as he twisted aside.

Shhk!

His hair fluttered. Blood sprayed from the gash cut into his forehead by the pressure alone, blinding him.

Damn it.

Jin Mukyung’s body jerked to a halt for an instant. His two years of training had made losing his sight no problem—but the blood in his eyes was enough to shake his composure.

For Jamukha, it was the perfect opening.

A chance to uproot the young Sword Demon, still unfinished but full of potential.

“If you’d put that collar on yourself, this wouldn’t have happened.”

Jamukha raised his crescent saber, his voice low.

He surpassed the Demon Bird in every respect. Even facing Jin Mukyung, exhausted to the limit, he did not let his guard down.

Calmly and without a word, he found the fastest, most precise path and brought his saber down.

Farewell, young Sword Demon.

Blue-green Force flowed along the smooth blade, about to cut through the air—

Whoosh! Whoom!

With a fearsome whistle, a great saber shot in like a bolt of lightning and plunged squarely between Jamukha and Jin Mukyung.

Kaboom!

Beyond the boom that sounded as though the sky had split and the cloud of dust rising pale in its wake, the towering old man appeared. He bared his teeth in a grin at Jamukha.

“Ready to die?”

At the sight of the Thunderbolt Saber King drenched in blood from head to toe, Jamukha replied in fluent Chinese.

“Thanks for saying what I was about to.”

For Jamukha, nothing had changed.

Nothing at all.

Chapter 966

If two martial artists were evenly matched, what decided a life-and-death duel? For ages, that question had been a favorite topic among the gossips of the martial world.

Some said it was superior internal energy and peerless martial arts. Others put a divine weapon first. Still others insisted it was an unshakable mind and exceptional physical ability.

Every one of those answers was right. And every one was wrong.

Masters who had reached a certain realm knew. They had felt it firsthand.

In a life-and-death duel, a single difference—however small, however trivial it might seem—could decide the outcome.

That was why they often agreed on one thing:

What martial art you've learned isn't all that important. What matters most is having the eyes and instincts to see through your opponent's movements.

And now, everyone in the gorge understood exactly what those words meant, though they had once seemed so distant.

Whoosh! Kaboom!

They couldn't see the movements. They couldn't even sense them.

They could only stare, dazed, forgetting for a moment to swing their blades at the enemies before them.

Beyond the endless flashes and thunderous booms, three figures tangled together at speeds too great to see.

Whoom!

An absurdly massive saber cleaved through the air. The mighty Force along its edge tore through Jamukha's body with the wind.

Or seemed to.

Shhk.

A single step.

Jamukha's form blurred for an instant, then reappeared about ten feet away.

He had dodged the attack with a ghostly movement. Just as he surged toward the Thunderbolt Saber King, a faint whistle sounded from beyond his blind spot.

Shwaa!

In that instant, Jamukha was reminded of something.

The Thunderbolt Saber King wasn't the only enemy he had to defeat here today.

Shk—KABOOM!

The crescent saber met a gleaming white sword.

Amid the shock wave and deafening boom that reverberated through the gorge, Jamukha took an unexpected step back. A smile formed at the corner of his mouth.

Impressive. Even better than I expected.

His gaze fell on Jin Mukyung, who had been driven back, carving a deep furrow through the ground.

The young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had delivered an unexpected strike despite his battered body.

And at last, Jamukha understood how Jin Mukyung, who had only just broken through to Supreme Peak, had defeated the Demon Bird, a master firmly established in that realm.

The sword Mukyung wielded had neither the prescribed movements nor the shapes considered fundamental to martial arts.

Only One Strike.

He found the fastest, most perfect path to end his opponent's life, then took it.

And that strike, driven by the will to kill, carried far greater power than Mukyung's own martial prowess should have allowed.

Enough to defeat the Demon Bird, a superior master, in the realm of Supreme Peak, where a single form could decide the fight.

But…

This is as far as it goes.

Without a word anyone could hear, Jamukha shook out both arms.

Green Force, like the vast grasslands where he had been born and raised, surged along his crescent saber and his empty hand.

Fwoosh!

Beyond the blinding flash swelling to an immense size, the two streams of Force shot in different directions.

One toward the Thunderbolt Saber King, who was bringing his great saber down as if to cleave the world in two.

The other toward Jin Mukyung, who was staggering and swallowing blood.

The result went far beyond what one man had expected.

Craaaack!

The Thunderbolt Saber King's eyes widened as he stared at the two blades locked together without the slightest give.

What in the—!

He was a warrior to the bone. He had made his name in the Great Faction War and become a living legend, yet he had never underestimated an opponent standing before him.

And still, his full-powered strike had been blocked.

With astonishing ease.

As though his opponent had seen through both the form and the flow of the martial art he had used.

"How could you…!"

Confusion and anger mingled in his voice.

The two blades remained locked in midair, their wielders' bodies still apart. Jamukha looked at the Thunderbolt Saber King with calm eyes.

"I'm disappointed. Shouldn't you have saved your much younger junior first, Thunderbolt Saber King?"

"…!"

The Thunderbolt Saber King's eyes wavered.

Over Jamukha's shoulder, he belatedly saw Jin Mukyung on his knees, vomiting blood, unable to withstand the force of the palm strike.

Damn it.

A mistake.

No—a grievous misjudgment.

Jamukha was stronger than he had thought, and he was a far more formidable master, with deeper secrets.

BOOM!

After a fierce contest of strength, their sabers finally tore apart with a deafening boom.

The Thunderbolt Saber King let the force of the impact pass through him, then brought his great saber down at Jamukha again.

Fwoosh!

A strike combining his innate divine strength with several jiazi[3525] of internal energy.

Born the third son of the Hebei Peng Family, he had become its Family Head and the Thunderbolt Saber King through the family's peerless martial art, the Primordial Thunderbolt Saber. Now it fell like a bolt of lightning.

As if it would split the world in two along with the enemy before him.

Shing! KRAAAASH!

A keen slicing sound rang out as the gorge shook.

Yet even after delivering a strike worthy of one of the Ten Kings, the Thunderbolt Saber King swept his gaze over the area, eyes grave, while a hazy cloud of dust billowed around him.

Where is he?

He had swung his saber countless times and cut down more than a thousand people, by his estimate.

[3525] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

So he knew better than anyone:

That strike had cut through wind and earth, not a man's flesh and bone.

"You bastard!"

The Thunderbolt Saber King roared like a tiger and swung his great saber.

Beyond the dust cloud scattering under the force of his blow, Jamukha was crouched in silence, like a wolf preparing to hunt.

Hup.

Neither moved first.

As if on cue, both men shot toward each other.

No one there could see the teeth and claws of the great tiger from the Hebei Peng Family or the wolf of the Great Steppe—so fast and so powerful were they.

BOOM! BOOM! KRAAA-BOOM!

Every time their sabers collided, a boom like cannon fire rang out.

The screams of those caught in the tremendous shock waves sweeping across the gorge rose over the noise.

"Gwaaaah!"

Arms and legs tore from bodies. Fountains of blood shot into the air.

Beyond a thick haze of blood, flashes of light kept sparking without pause. The nomads caught at the heart of the calamity fled for their lives.

Some ran toward the relatively safe entrance at the rear.

Others ran toward the exit at the opposite end.

Those with no choice but to take the latter route found themselves face-to-face with a forest of spears and blades, now almost upon them.

Thud-thud-thud!

Dozens of nomads, unable to dodge the arrows raining down from the still-standing earthen rampart, fell like pincushions. The blades in the hands of Shanxi fighters flashed as they pressed forward, trampling the crumbling bodies.

Shhk!

Jin Wikyung was exhausted, but the keen edge of his sword had lost none of its bite.

Having cut through a crescent saber and its wielder, he steadied his ragged breathing and advanced.

Toward the enemies inside the gorge, who had once seemed endless no matter how many they killed, but were now being swept away like a wave.

Toward the heart of the gorge, where two monsters were locked in a fierce battle.

Danger?

It didn't matter.

The arrow had already been loosed. If they retreated now, only a defeat they could never undo awaited them all.

We have to seize the gorge and drive them out as soon as possible. That's our only chance.

The arrival of the Hebei Peng Family, led by the Thunderbolt Saber King, had greatly improved the desperate battle situation. But Jin Wikyung's cool head saw every detail of the position his side was in.

This momentum is only temporary. If the enemy regains their composure, the tide will turn again.

The Hebei Peng Family was undoubtedly strong.

Its power reached beyond its home province of Hebei to encompass the entire north alongside the Murong Family. And the Thunderbolt Saber King, a peerless Supreme Peak master, could take on an army by himself.

But the enemy was strong, too.

Jamukha was fighting the Thunderbolt Saber King without giving an inch, and beyond the gorge, tens of thousands of steppe warriors were still fighting the Hebei Peng Family.

Their morale had faltered, but they still outnumbered the Hebei Peng Family ten to one—perhaps more.

Even after thousands of their soldiers had been killed or put out of action in the narrow gorge, the fundamental gap in their forces remained.

There was only one answer.

To win a battle still hanging in the balance, they had to keep advancing with everything they had until the very end.

"Follow me!"

Jin Wikyung shouted at the top of his lungs and charged.

His body now soaked in blood, he plunged into the crumbling enemy line and swung his sword like a madman.

Craaaack!

He had too much to protect.

The people who followed him, ready to give their lives.

The land where they had been born and raised.

And, far in the distance, his little brother, staggering back to his feet despite his grievous internal injuries.

Jin Wikyung couldn't give up any of it.

Not one thing.

Whatever else happened, Jin Wikyung's judgment was right.

Outside the gorge, the terrain opened into a broad basin beyond its narrow, jar-like entrance. There, the battle raged on without either side giving an inch.

Thud-thud-thud!

Shhk! KRAAA-BOOM!

The Hebei Peng Family and the nomads.

The nomads and the Hebei Peng Family.

The two forces had shared a border and been at odds for many years. Now they swung their weapons and shouted themselves hoarse as if facing the enemies of a lifetime.

“They’re weak barbarians! Crush them in one blow!”

“Brothers of the Great Steppe! Will you retreat before a mere handful of Han Chinese?”

Those cries, carried on the wind as they rang out against each other, perfectly reflected the situation they were in.

The Hebei Peng Family’s martial artists were individually superior. But the nomads outnumbered them more than ten to one, surrounded them on all sides, and attacked without pause.

“Attack! Don’t fall back—surround them!”

“Break through!”

Sharp spears against enormous shields.

If the Thunderbolt Saber King had stayed, the Hebei Peng Family would have held the advantage. But after throwing the enemy ranks into disarray, he had headed into the gorge with some of his elite fighters. The nomads had quickly closed the gap in their encirclement and counterattacked.

Still, a trace of unease lingered in their hearts.

If this keeps up…

This is bad. Very bad.

The Keshik centurions Jamukha had left outside the gorge exchanged grim looks.

The Hebei Peng Family’s sudden arrival had sent the morale of the Shanxi fighters soaring, while brutally crushing the nomads’ momentum.

There was the imposing presence of a master like the Thunderbolt Saber King.

And there was the Hebei Peng Family’s reputation, which had kept the nomads from daring to encroach on Hebei.

Some of the centurions were already reaching inside their robes without realizing it.

If we use that now, we could turn this battle around in an instant.

But the thought quickly faded.

They remembered Jamukha’s order—the command of the absolute ruler of the Great Steppe, the lord they served.

“No one uses it without my order. This won’t be the last battle we have to fight.”

They had not objected to that firm command or doubted it in the slightest.

Not simply because they were his subjects, but because it was Jamukha who had given it.

Jamukha was always coolheaded and certain. Everything he had said so far had proved right, and this would, too.

That wouldn’t change even if the opponent was the Thunderbolt Saber King.

They had only one small question.

What made him so certain?

Before they reached Shanxi Province, Jamukha had already predicted that other enemies would come to the aid of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

And he had declared without a trace of doubt:

“Nothing will change. Nothing at all.”

As the centurions recalled those words from several days ago and watched the battlefield with questioning eyes—

Rrrrattle.

Beyond the vast basin, where tens of thousands of enemies and allies were tangled together, a group suddenly emerged from the darkness. All at once, they drew their bows.

Shwaaaaa!

Beneath the storm clouds, thousands of arrowheads flashed as they cut through the wind and plunged down.

Chapter 967

To a martial artist, martial arts were like fingerprints: each person's took a different shape.

Even disciples who studied under the same master, learned the same martial arts, and followed the same formulas would move differently according to their temperaments and physical traits.

A man who doesn't fear death might use a sword technique more boldly than prescribed. Someone with short arms and legs might widen their stride when using a footwork technique.

And at that moment, something about Jamukha felt strangely familiar to Peng Cheolhu, the Thunderbolt Saber King.

BOOM! BOOM! KRAAA-BOOM!

The two saber blades clashed without pause, accompanied by a barrage of fierce impacts.

Beyond them, Jamukha's calm face—and every movement he made—grew more familiar the longer the Thunderbolt Saber King watched.

What is it?

For a martial artist who had reached a high realm, letting his mind wander during a life-and-death duel was forbidden.

Yet the Thunderbolt Saber King kept watching Jamukha, breaking that rule until he finally recalled a scene buried deep in his memory.

Could it be?

His eyes flew wide.

Jamukha seized that instant of distraction and brought his crescent saber down with all his might.

BOOM! KRRRACK!

Two sabers worthy of being called treasured blades locked together, scattering sparks.

Neither man gave an inch. The Thunderbolt Saber King studied Jamukha's face beyond their crossed blades, his gaze growing grave.

"I wondered where a barbarian like you had come from… Now I see we've met before."

Jamukha was silent for a moment. Then he spoke in Chinese so fluent that no nomad from the western steppe, so far from the Central Plains, should have known it so well.

"So you finally remember. Your head's still as thick as ever, Thunderbolt Saber Peng Cheolhu."

"Thunderbolt Saber. There was a time when they called me that."

The Thunderbolt Saber King murmured as if to himself.

Only one character separated that title from his current one, but more than half a lifetime lay between them.

The first time the two had crossed paths was before the unprecedented Great War called the Great Faction War, back when Peng Cheolhu was the Lesser Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family.

I thought so. He's that barbarian from back then.

The Thunderbolt Saber King looked at Jamukha with fresh eyes.

It was a fragment of a memory more than half a century old. And yet he could still dredge it up from his aging mind because the young nomad, who had rampaged like a wolf despite his terrible injuries, had left such a powerful impression on him.

Right. That's how it was.

Nomads crossed the Great Wall and raided the borderlands. Those who lived there fought to protect their homes and possessions.

Such clashes were a fact of life along the frontier near the Great Steppe. Hebei, where the Peng Family stood like a great tree, was no exception.

What made this encounter different was the young chieftain who had risen to power amid the turmoil of the eastern steppe. He had set his sights on Hebei and brought thousands of warriors with him.

Even along a frontier accustomed to raids and resistance, that was rare.

No—it was the first large-scale invasion in over a decade.

Peng Cheolhu had led his family in place of the bedridden Family Head. Recognizing the gravity of the situation, the Murong Family had sent a thousand elite fighters to help, including its own Lesser Family Head.

The Hebei Peng Family and the Murong Family each held a place among the Five Great Families. Their forces were led by two Lesser Family Heads emerging as the finest young masters of their generation.

Before the Great Faction War, the two families had been at odds over supremacy in the north. Their dramatic alliance proved enough to secure a fitting reward.

A flawless victory, without a single misstep.

Or perhaps a glorious triumph.

No one in the world questioned either description.

So complete was their victory that the young chieftain of the eastern steppe, routed by Peng Cheolhu and the Hebei Peng Family, had barely escaped the Murong Family's pursuit when its fighters arrived.

Leaving behind only the blood of the countless warriors who had followed him.

Then he vanished without a trace, seemingly forever.

Or so everyone, including the Thunderbolt Saber King, had believed.

Until they met again today.

“I never thought you’d still be alive. You’re a hard one to kill.”

They said a needle in a bag would eventually poke through. Someone that sharp was bound to reveal himself—even if he was out on the vast steppe rather than inside a bag.

Yet the young chieftain, with ambition and skill to spare, had not shown himself for more than half a century. The nomads had never invaded Hebei again.

That was why the Thunderbolt Saber King had forgotten Jamukha.

Barbarian or not, a man of his ability would not have failed to rise again without good reason. Peng Cheolhu had assumed that the wounds he’d inflicted that day had killed him, or that he’d fallen victim to another conflict on the steppe.

Whatever had happened, Peng Cheolhu had been certain of the outcome: Jamukha was dead.

“I should’ve done whatever it took to root you out back then. I should’ve torn out the source of this trouble.”

The Thunderbolt Saber King sighed quietly across their locked blades. Jamukha saw him reflected in his own gleaming eyes.

“I couldn’t die. Not before I repaid an old debt.”

Jamukha spat out the words.

How could he forget that bitter past?

He had returned from Hebei in defeat, then left the eastern steppe with the surviving members of his tribe. After marching thousands of li,[3526] he had reached its distant western edge and raised a ger[3527] of his own.

There, he could no longer see the hated banners of the Hebei Peng Family. There, he could avoid the teeth of the wolves waiting for his downfall. He settled in and waited for his chance to rise again.

Some fifty years flowed by like a river.

So much changed.

The new name he had taken to avoid a possible pursuit—Jamukha—had become a symbol of authority across the western steppe. His ranks teemed with fine steeds and warriors like hunting dogs. The few dozen gers[3528] he had started with had grown into tens of thousands of households.

But even when he had become all but king of the steppe, Jamukha had not forgotten Peng Cheolhu’s saber cutting across his body like a bolt of lightning.

Nor had he forgotten the humiliation of that defeat.

Wooooom.

[3526] In this setting, one Chinese li is 500 m (0.311 mi). Thousands of li amount to at least 1,000 km (621 mi).

[3527] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomads on the steppe.

[3528] A ger is a portable, round dwelling traditionally used by nomads on the steppe.

The green Force around his crescent saber set the air trembling as it swelled larger and larger.

In Jamukha's gaze, fixed on the Thunderbolt Saber King, lay a past he had yet to put to rest.

"Thunderbolt Saber. No—Thunderbolt Saber King Peng Cheolhu."

The young chieftain who had dreamed of restoring his ancestors' achievements had returned as the absolute ruler of the steppe, leading a vast army. The Lesser Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family, who had taken everything from him, had come through the Great Faction War to become one of the Ten Kings—a great tree supporting the martial world.

One thing, though, had not changed: their old grudge.

"Do you still not understand?"

Krrrrk.

The crescent saber, engulfed in radiant green Force, pressed down on the great saber.

The Thunderbolt Saber King groaned as his blade trembled. Jamukha's lips twisted.

"I waited. I waited for you—for the Hebei Peng Family—to appear here."

"…!"

The Thunderbolt Saber King's eyes widened at the unexpected words.

KA-BOOM!

With a thunderclap that seemed to split the sky, the great saber—until then like a colossal wall—was forced back, unable to withstand the crescent saber's power.

KRAAAASH!

A gale swept through. Part of the rocky cliff cracked and burst apart under the terrible pressure.

Yet even amid the dust swirling around them, Jamukha moved with precision and speed.

Shwaa!

Space split along his saber's path. Streams of green Force shot from the crescent-shaped blade toward the retreating Thunderbolt Saber King.

BOOM! BOOM!

The roar of the two sabers colliding had already gone beyond the realm of steel.

Jamukha's gaze, so composed until now, had begun to boil like lava. So had the voice rising from his lips.

Just like—

"I'll kill you! Every last one of you!"

—the young chieftain who had lost everything in a bitter defeat and been forced to leave.

FWOOOSH!

Green Force erupted from his saber with all his strength. The dazzling beam lit the gorge like an early dawn as it slashed diagonally toward the Thunderbolt Saber King.

Shhk!

A single, chilling sound of something being cut rang out amid the flash.

"Cough."

Thud, thud.

The Thunderbolt Saber King staggered backward, spat out a mouthful of blood, and looked at Jamukha. Pain from his internal injuries twisted his deeply furrowed brow.

"…Impressive. Truly impressive."

There was no sarcasm in his voice. He meant it.

As a martial artist and a warrior who carried on the Peng Family's legacy, the Thunderbolt Saber King admired Jamukha's patience through all those years spent seeking revenge for his defeat. He admired his astonishing martial prowess.

And he admired Jamukha himself—a man who had kept his wits about him to the very end, even with his revenge almost within reach.

"How did you think to pull back? You had the perfect chance."

Even an enemy deserved respect when he had shown courage and fighting spirit worthy of praise.

But Jamukha did not answer the Thunderbolt Saber King's question.

No—he couldn't answer.

Crack.

The sound was so faint it could only be heard by someone listening closely. His crescent saber trembled, and in the next instant—

KA-BOOM!

—the blade shattered. Blood spraying from Jamukha's shoulder fell onto the fragments of steel.

FWASH! THUD-THUD-THUD!

The blood bursting through his skin was red. Pain surged from his deeply cut shoulder and his internal organs, hot as lightning, as fire.

Through the searing agony, Jamukha steadied himself and spoke.

"Cough. How—how did you…?"

He could not understand it.

The martial arts of the Hebei Peng Family were the very embodiment of domineering power. For generations, its members had made their name throughout the world with strength honed through training and explosive internal

energy cultivated through their techniques. That reliance was also their one limitation.

So Jamukha had pursued speed above all else.

For the past fifty years, he had trained in saber techniques of the utmost speed and studied the Thunderbolt Saber King's martial arts, believing the speed he had perfected would overcome the Hebei Peng Family's overwhelming power.

But—

"Why? How…!"

As the Thunderbolt Saber King approached, steadying himself despite his internal injuries, Jamukha cried out, his voice thick with blood.

Unlike Jamukha, who had been unable to answer the earlier question, the Thunderbolt Saber King replied calmly.

"The Great Faction War. On that damn battlefield, I learned there were plenty of monsters in this world worse than this old man."

Enlightenment had no end. Progress was not a privilege reserved for the young.

Especially not for an old master like the Thunderbolt Saber King.

"Among them, there was this crazy old man who toyed with me and laughed at me. Said I was built like a bear and moved like molasses."

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

Hoping to surpass that deranged old monster someday, Peng Cheolhu had kept training even after peace returned.

He had not missed a single day.

"Still don't understand?"

The Thunderbolt Saber King raised his massive saber upright and looked at Jamukha, who was groaning as he clutched his half-severed shoulder.

"How Peng Cheolhu, the Thunderbolt Saber, became the Thunderbolt Saber King?"

Only one character separated the two titles.

But in this vast world, only ten great martial artists had earned the right to be called kings. They stood beneath the endless sky and three stars.

"The only place you can be called a king is out there on the steppe."

Peng Cheolhu, the Thunderbolt Saber King, looked at Jamukha's wide eyes and laughed aloud.

Chapter 968

Someone once said:

When three people walk together, one of them is sure to have something to teach me.

Of course, the Thunderbolt Saber King wasn't sure whether it had been Confucius or Mencius.[3529]

But the main reason he was smiling now was that he'd thought of someone who wasn't there.

If it weren't for the Fire King—that crazy old man—I'd never have grown stronger.

He had spent his life in the spotlight. Not merely because he'd been born into the Hebei Peng Family, one of the Five Great Families, but because he had the talent and skill to earn that attention.

Namgung Cheon. Murong Baek. Peng Cheolhu.

Of all the young prodigies born to prestigious families, those three had stood above the rest. Unexpected misfortune had kept Murong Baek from joining the other two at the top, while Namgung Cheon and Peng Cheolhu had come to be known as the Sword King and the Saber King.

But the Thunderbolt Saber King knew why he had made it that far.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

That old man had laid into him at every opportunity. Without him, Peng Cheolhu would have kept treading water instead of growing stronger.

"I'll tell you something. That grassland you were born and raised on isn't as vast as you think."

The Thunderbolt Saber King slowly raised his great saber toward Jamukha, who trembled as he clutched the shoulder Peng's Force had nearly severed.

Toward the king of the steppe, holding back a groan before a giant who stood tall beneath heaven.

"Now, let's finish this."

Whoosh.

With a single step, the space between them vanished.

The Thunderbolt Saber King's form blurred. For a man of his enormous build, he moved at an unbelievable speed, yet the path of the great saber plunging down like lightning was precise and controlled.

Shhk!

A single slicing sound rang out. Pain spread through Jamukha like fire, and he clenched his teeth against the scream rising in his throat.

Ghk…!

[3529] Mencius was a Chinese philosopher associated with the Confucian tradition.

He'd dodged. He should have dodged.

But the wound in his shoulder throbbed without cease. The Thunderbolt Saber King's internal energy had seeped through it and shaken his organs, slowing his feet.

Wooooom.

A resonant hum filled everyone's ears.

Jamukha's crescent saber lay shattered. The Thunderbolt Saber King's great saber bore only a few scratches. It trembled, then surged forward once more.

No. It split as it advanced.

The single blade became five, then ten, then dozens. Its afterimages formed an enormous net and shot forward.

The Thunderbolt Saber King spoke quietly.

"Go."

There was certainty in his voice and in his eyes as he faced Jamukha. Not a trace of carelessness toward a wounded, bleeding enemy—only confidence in his own strike and his own skill.

Fwoooosh!

The net of Force swept down. Jamukha threw himself backward, but the immense energy stayed close on his heels, cutting through everything it touched.

The cliffs on either side. The rocks and corpses scattered across the ground.

Even the loyal men who rushed in to save him.

"Stop him! The Khan is in danger—!"

Puk! Fwooooooosh!

No scream followed.

Those who had rushed forward with desperate cries crumpled into dozens of chunks of flesh. Jamukha, teeth clenched, reached for a weapon abandoned by its owner.

Woom.

The air shuddered. A crescent saber flew into his hand, drawn by Seizing an Object Through Empty Space, and he unleashed a burst of Force.

BOOM!

Part of the net scattered. Jamukha swallowed the blood that surged up his throat as the impact shook his entire body.

His saber techniques, wielded with only one arm, were slower. Every time he met a strike head-on, the impact battered his insides, which kept screaming in pain.

But—

Do you think I'll die like this? And at your hands?

With that cry in his heart, Jamukha sent his crescent saber flashing in every direction.

Thunderous impacts rang out, flashes of light filling his vision. Beyond them, the distant past swept through his mind: his younger self struggling to survive, clenching his teeth until they bled as he swore revenge. And the voice of someone who had willingly reached out to him.

“Don’t you want to live?”

He had thought everything was over.

The warriors who had once numbered in the thousands had been all but wiped out by the Hebei Peng Family’s elite, led by Peng Cheolhu. His rivals had been waiting for his fall. They would take his livestock and wealth, then enslave the few people his tribe had left.

That was the law of the steppe, passed down through the survival of the strong.

But just when he thought it was over, one last chance appeared.

Sitting amid the wreckage of his ambitions and the bodies of his men, the young chieftain seized the hand held out to him—the lifeline dropped from heaven—with all his strength.

“I want to live. No—I must survive!”

“If you live, what will you live for?”

“Revenge. I’ll repay today’s humiliation and grudge, no matter what. If you save me, I swear by Tengri[3530]…”

“I’m not helping you.”

“What do you mean?”

“I’m using you.”

“…!”

He did not think for long. The decision he made in that instant was as firm as an iron tower.

“Show me the path I must follow, my lord.”

The savior smiled, pleased to see him prostrate himself like a slave. He pointed beyond the endless horizon.

“Go. Build a new home where neither the Hebei Peng Family nor the eyes of the Central Plains can reach you.”

“You mean I should head west?”

“Don’t worry. The west is still in chaos, and you’re no longer alone. You have ‘us’ now.”

“Us…”

“Yes. We’ll help you, Jamukha—warrior of the Great Steppe, reborn here today.”

The savior had been right.

[3530]Tengri is the sky deity in traditional Mongol and other Central Asian beliefs.

The young chieftain left with a new name and soon distinguished himself on the western steppe. The greatest reason he was able to build such a powerful force was the savior's support.

Livestock and wealth in vast quantities. Even people and information.

"They're quite capable. Make good use of them."

And so Jamukha's personal guard, the Keshik, was born.

"These are supreme martial arts for you to learn, along with the Hebei Peng Family's martial arts. They don't include the secret techniques passed down to only a select few, but studying them will certainly help you."

The savior had even given him a sword and shield with which to face the enemy of a lifetime—the man who had since become the Thunderbolt Saber King.

Clang!

The crash shattered his reverie. Blood burst from his torn palm, and Jamukha swung his crescent saber wildly at the net of Force bearing down on him.

One arm was useless, its flesh, muscle, and even bone torn apart. But the immense internal energy he had accumulated over long years still flowed into his fingertips, along with the supreme martial arts he had learned.

So did a memory from years after he had settled on the western steppe.

"Tell me. When should we march?"

"Not yet. Wait. You are not to leave the west until you receive an explicit order."

"Not yet? How much longer must I wait?"

What?

"If I keep waiting for that order, we'll miss our chance. The Central Plains are in turmoil because of the Great Faction War. If we strike Hebei now…"

"Remarkable. A hunting dog that speaks like a man."

"…!"

"Draw your saber. Now."

The savior's eyes filled with killing intent. Jamukha did not refuse. He charged—and found himself facing a wall that seemed even higher and more imposing than the one he had encountered against Peng Cheolhu in his youth. He fell to his knees.

Only then did he understand.

"Remember this. Until 'that person' gives the order, we do not move."

"…That person?"

Even the savior, who had seemed like heaven itself to Jamukha, was someone else's hunting dog.

From the beginning, the "us" he spoke of had meant something far deeper and more powerful than Jamukha had imagined.

"Keep that in mind until the day you take your revenge and claim the steppe. You will not be forgiven twice."

Jamukha felt neither humiliation nor defiance. He trembled with fear and joy.

If he followed the owner of the leash around his neck, he could reach the goal that had seemed to be slipping farther and farther away. Once that master had swallowed the world, he would toss the vast Great Steppe to the hunting dog who had carried out his task.

"…As you command."

From that day on, every trace of defiance vanished from Jamukha's heart. Years passed, frost settling in his hair, until one day he realized the time had finally come.

"What is this?"

"A kind of pill. It lets you draw on power beyond your limits for a short time, though you'll pay a price to match."

Its effects were too ominous for a spiritual elixir. The savior called it a Temporary Strength Pill.

"Why are you giving it to me?"

"Consider it an experiment. For the near future."

"Then… could it be?"

"That person has awakened. Begin building a bridgehead for our advance into the Central Plains."

"…!"

After a wait of more than fifty years, the last few years passed in a flash.

On orders, Jamukha scattered pills and a number of martial arts manuals across the steppe. Each pill found its own owner. Armed with power they could never have imagined, those people spread chaos and disrupted the established order.

Not just on the steppe, but in the Central Plains beyond the Great Wall.

Pung Yang.

The leader of the mounted bandits known as the Red Wind Band on the eastern steppe was an ambitious man. With the Temporary Strength Pill's help, he built his forces at an astonishing pace. Then he turned his horse toward Shanxi Province and met his death there.

His killer was the scion of a borderland martial family in slow decline, a young man with the unfamiliar epithet Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi.

Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung…

Roughly two years passed. So much happened in that time.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan rose to rule Shanxi Province. On the eastern steppe, where Jamukha's old name had been forgotten, two young upstarts named Temur

and Chinggen distinguished themselves. Far away in the Central Plains, the Star-Array Grand Banquet was held.

Then, like dams breaking one after another, everything that had been held back burst forth.

The bloodshed began with Shaolin Temple in Henan, swept through Sichuan and Anhui, then spread as far as distant Yunnan.

The Sleeping Dragon of Shanxi came to be called the Divine Dragon. Sensing danger, the people of the Central Plains gathered under the Murim Alliance's banner. Even the great sects drew back, wary of an enemy blade that might strike at any moment.

Of course, none of this applied to Jamukha.

Dark Heaven, which everyone in the Central Plains dreaded, was "us" to him.

This was the moment he had waited for all his life.

"By the coming Double Ninth Festival,[3531] take control of the eastern steppe. Mobilize every soldier and seize Shanxi."

Jamukha summoned his warriors at once. After so long a wait, he moved with lightning speed.

At last he assembled an army drawn from across the steppe. The savior, meanwhile, passed along timely news from beyond the Great Wall.

The strength of Shanxi Province, gathered around the Jin Family of Taiyuan. The place where the fiercest fighting was expected.

And one last thing.

"The Thunderbolt Saber King will go there. Without fail."

He had even given Jamukha the place where he could finally settle his oldest grudge.

Everything had happened as the savior predicted.

Except for one thing.

Why? Why?!

With a cry that circled only on the tip of his tongue, Jamukha twisted his unsteady body around.

Shhk! Puh-puh-puk!

Pain like a branding iron.

He could see the attacks coming. His mind registered them. His body simply could not move fast enough.

The net of Force that had pursued him relentlessly had faded after leaving dozens of large and small wounds across his body. But beyond it stood a great tiger that would never let its prey escape.

Lips pressed tight. Eyes alight with a cold flame.

[3531] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth month of the lunar calendar.

Both hands gripped the great saber so hard they had gone white. Brilliant light enveloped the blade from end to end.

Whoooom.

The Thunderbolt Saber King swung without hesitation. Jamukha watched the terrible strike, a fusion of defeat and swiftness, cut through the air.

And he understood.

Only one choice remained. Even if that choice left him drained and collapsed in this narrow gorge, it would be a hundred—a thousand—times better than dying at the Thunderbolt Saber King's hands.

Shk.

As the Force came at him from several yards away, the world seemed to slow. Jamukha took something from inside his robe.

He tossed the small, blood-red pill into his mouth without hesitation.

Or tried to.

At that very moment, a flash of light fell from above.

Thuk!

Through a stab of pain and disbelief, Jamukha saw a spearhead gleaming in five colors.

It had pierced the back of his hand—and the Temporary Strength Pill in his grasp. His last hope.

"…!"

Jamukha looked up, forgetting even the pain.

The owner of the spear that had fallen from the darkened sky spoke not to Jamukha, but to the Thunderbolt Saber King.

"With people like this, no amount of caution is ever enough. Don't you agree?"

Shwaa!

The great saber, poised to sweep everything away, whistled through the air and stopped.

The Thunderbolt Saber King recognized the face. A surprised smile touched his lips.

"I knew you'd come."

He looked at the graying, middle-aged man, who appeared twenty years younger than he truly was, and spoke with deep feeling.

"It's been a long time, Murong Baek. Or should I call you Family Head Murong now?"

They had fought countless times for supremacy in the north. Through the Great Faction War, they had become true comrades and friends. The Thunderbolt Saber King grinned broadly at Murong Baek and lowered his saber.

Good.

The war was over.

Jamukha could no longer fight, and the elite fighters Murong Baek had brought from the Murong Family must already have joined the battle.

Just as he expected, a shout rose from beyond the gorge.

“The Murong Family! It’s the Murong Family!”

The tension that had held the Thunderbolt Saber King’s entire body taut began to ease.

At least, until a panicked shout from someone who was surely a member of the Hebei Peng Family followed in the next moment.

“Grand Family Head! The enemy—the Murong Family—!”

What?

For an instant, the Thunderbolt Saber King’s thoughts stopped. A sudden chill sank deep into his body.

Shhk!

Through the blinding pain, he heard a quiet voice.

“I told you. You can never be too careful.”

“…!”

As his vision faded, the Thunderbolt Saber King understood.

Jamukha.

The young chieftain who should have lost all his forces and died a defeated man—how had he shaken off his pursuers and survived until now?

The Murong Family.

Of course.

More than fifty years ago, the man who had pursued him was Murong Baek.

The true source of all this calamity.

Chapter 969

The people of Shanxi didn’t see what happened in that fleeting moment.

They were throwing all their strength into driving back the enemies who filled the gaps among the corpses of men and horses and between the scattered rocks.

No—even if they’d been nearby, they wouldn’t have seen a thing.

The strike was so natural and swift that it could deceive the Qi Sense of a Supreme Peak master ranked among the top three of the Ten Kings.

Shhk!

Through pain that felt like fire, the Thunderbolt Saber King summoned superhuman endurance to keep his body from collapsing.

He trembled at the unbelievable truth that had struck him like a giant iron hammer.

So that’s what happened.

Now he knew. At last, he understood.

Why the young chieftain who had crossed the Great Wall and invaded Hebei had survived.

Why a man who, for all his ambition and skill, had been no more than an exceptional nomad had gained such powerful internal energy and learned martial arts unknown on the steppe.

That day, Jamukha hadn’t survived.

He’d been spared.

By the Murong Family that had pursued him. By the man who had led them.

Murong Baek.

His vision blurred with rage and pain. Pressing a trembling hand to the deep gash in his chest to stop the bleeding, the Thunderbolt Saber King stared in shock at the middle-aged man before him.

His features looked as though they belonged somewhere between the Han Chinese and the nomads.

“Impressive. You managed to react even then.”

His voice was as still as a quiet pond.

Yet his sword—when had he drawn it?—was already coming down like a flash of light.

Whoosh!

The air screamed.

The Thunderbolt Saber King’s eyes widened at the merciless strike from Murong Baek, whom he had believed to be his friend.

Twisting away on instinct at the last moment had saved his life, but nothing more.

The Force that had cut deep across his chest left his whole body heavy as soaked cotton.

Boom! Krrrk!

His great saber wavered as it barely caught the sword.

Murong Baek let out a quiet exclamation. Even with his internal energy in disarray, the Thunderbolt Saber King had blocked the attack.

“As I thought. You’re still absurdly strong.”

“Murong Baek, how could you…!”

The Thunderbolt Saber King clenched his teeth until blood came.

The Murong Family and the Hebei Peng Family.

The Hebei Peng Family and the Murong Family.

It was true that the two families, known throughout the world, had once been at odds.

But that was the past.

An old feud long since buried by the years.

Even now, the Thunderbolt Saber King could hardly believe that Murong Baek had betrayed him. Murong Baek, who had fought back-to-back with him in the Great Faction War. The rival of his youth who had become his friend, who had grown old alongside him.

No. He had betrayed everyone on this land.

“When? When did you…”

His breathing was ragged with anger and shock. Beyond the trembling blades, he fixed the traitor with his gaze and moved his split lips.

“When did you join hands with Dark Heaven?”

Murong Baek answered by pressing his sword harder against the great saber. Force surged along the blade toward its tip.

Shhk.

The Thunderbolt Saber King swallowed a groan.

It burned. Murong Baek’s Force had reached his skin before the sword, and now it was digging into his collarbone.

Slowly. Little by little.

Cutting through flesh and bone as though it would not stop until it reached his heart.

“Graaaah!”

Blood burst between his clenched teeth.

Roaring like a furious tiger, the Thunderbolt Saber King drove his great saber upward.

His rage blotted out the pain. Through the Chaos Thunderbolt Divine Art, reserved for the Hebei Peng Family Head, he poured every last bit of internal energy in his body into the blade.

BOOM!

With a crash like the sky splitting apart, Murong Baek's sword was knocked away.

Agony tore through his damaged acupoints and the collarbone split by Force. The Thunderbolt Saber King endured it with a will harder than steel and thrust out his hand.

"You bastard!"

Poom!

Compressed air burst outward.

A strike from the Great Strength Vajra Palm, a technique the Hebei Peng Family took pride in, swept toward Murong Baek with such ferocity that it outran its own sound.

For the briefest moment, at least, that was how it looked.

Shwaa!

A flash of light—and it was over.

Murong Baek's figure blurred as he cut apart the palm force flying with the wind. The instant the Thunderbolt Saber King thought he saw him disappear, a red warning light flashed in his mind.

Shifting Form and Position!

There was no time to stop the bleeding from his collarbone. No time to swing his great saber.

He twisted with all his strength and turned toward the fleeting presence behind him, throwing a punch.

Whoosh.

It connected.

Not with a human body of flesh and bone, but with the wind, crushed beneath his fist.

At the same instant, he sensed it: a flash of light shooting beneath the fist he'd swung through empty air, scattering icy killing intent.

"…!"

The world slowed. Eyes wide, the Thunderbolt Saber King moved by instinct rather than reason.

He let go of the great saber he had carried all his life and reached for the flash closing in on his chest.

Thuk.

The sound of flesh being pierced rang out, sharp and slow.

The pointed sword tip drove through the Palm Force he'd hastily summoned as though it were tofu, cut through the flesh and bone of his hand, and emerged from the back of it.

As though that obstacle were nothing, it kept driving toward its target.

Until the Thunderbolt Saber King, holding back a scream, gripped the blade with all his strength.

Krrrk!

The sword stopped.

No—more precisely, it broke.

Plip.

Fragments of the blade fell with his blood.

His whole body went rigid under the overwhelming pain of his hand being crushed in an instant.

All he could do was stare, eyes wide, at Murong Baek staring back. Then he watched, dazed, as Murong Baek—without so much as a scratch on him—thrust out a palm.

Fwoosh.

Beyond the dazzling light filling his vision, Murong Baek's quiet voice reached him as faintly as a dream.

"You fought well. Like a true warrior."

And then—

Poom.

An explosion sounded deep inside his body, and the Thunderbolt Saber King's world turned upside down.

A massive tremor swept through the gorge.

KABOOM!

The ground shook. With a thunderous crash, part of the cliff collapsed.

Even rock built up by nature over ages too long to measure had given way. A human body of flesh stood no chance.

Krrrrk!

Boulders that had been part of the cliff came crashing down beneath the immense weight of earth and sand above them. Dust and debris flew wildly in every direction.

Yet even in the pale cloud, where he couldn't see a hand in front of his face, Murong Baek kept his eyes fixed on one spot.

He slowly closed the hand that had brought about this devastation, taking in

everything within several dozen *zhang*[3532] through his Qi Sense.

Including a faint cough that had just escaped from beneath a shifting mound of earth.

Khk.

Murong Baek didn't turn his head. He merely reached out and eased the weight of earth pressing down on the person who had coughed.

He retrieved something that had once belonged to him as well.

Wooooom.

The air shuddered as immense qi flowed from his gesture. Then a spear buried deep in the ground flew into his grasp as though pulled by an invisible string.

Fresh blood ran down it—proof that it had pierced someone's flesh and bone.

"Thank you."

Jamukha's voice came from behind him. Murong Baek spoke without turning.

"Why didn't you follow my orders? I told you to buy as much time as possible."

"Well…"

"I suppose you underestimated the Thunderbolt Saber King."

Jamukha bit his lip instead of answering.

Murong Baek was right. He had disobeyed his savior.

Holding his own against the Thunderbolt Saber King had made him greedy. Little by little, he had pushed aside Murong Baek's order to wait for him.

And there was one more order he had pushed aside.

He, at least, was never to take the Temporary Strength Pill.

"I have no excuse."

"No, you don't. If you'd swallowed it, we wouldn't be having this conversation."

The Temporary Strength Pill was a double-edged sword.

The early versions that had found their way into the hands of Pung Yang, the Red Wind Band Leader, and others were dangerous enough. Even the newly improved pill was highly addictive and carried severe side effects.

The ordinary foot soldiers might take it, but Jamukha could not. He was the commander-in-chief of a great army, with much yet to do.

Not from Murong Baek's point of view, when he had placed Jamukha at the forefront.

"How are you?"

"Not as bad as you might think. Once I finish regulating my qi, my Internal Injury should heal soon."

Despite his words, nearly half of one shoulder had been cut away. His future as a saber fighter was in danger, yet there was not a trace of gloom on his face.

[3532] Here, one *zhang* (Korean *jang*) is approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Jamukha knew how mysterious and powerful his savior's Dark Heaven was—the Dark Heaven Murong Baek had called "us" long ago.

With no worry at all showing on his face, he went on.

"Though that bastard will be wandering the Nine Springs[3533] now, unlike me."

That was when Murong Baek's gaze, fixed in one direction all this time, shifted to Jamukha.

"You still have a long way to go."

"What do you…?"

Jamukha trailed off. Suddenly understanding what Murong Baek meant, he bit his lip.

"You're saying he's alive? The Thunderbolt Saber King? Even now?"

It was a natural question.

He had seen what happened with his own eyes: the Thunderbolt Saber King crumbling beneath Murong Baek's attacks, delivered without hesitation or mercy.

A palm strike of terrifying power had driven him deep into the cliff, where he'd looked like a corpse as he spat blood.

But unlike Jamukha, Murong Baek could sense a thread of breath beneath the countless rocks and mounds of earth.

Stubborn bastard. Just as always.

Thinking back, the Thunderbolt Saber King—Peng Cheolhu—had always been like that.

His natural strength and sturdy body had made him stand out not only within the Hebei Peng Family but among the young prodigies of the entire world. The countless battlefields he had crossed had been no exception.

He always survived. Always.

So Murong Baek intended to end the Thunderbolt Saber King's life with his own hands.

And now that the cliffs had collapsed in front of and behind them, shutting out every witness nearby, he needed to kill all the survivors, including the Thunderbolt Saber King. Any one of them might pose a risk.

The longer his secret remained hidden, the better.

Then he could deal another devastating blow to the reinforcements coming from the Nine Sects and One Gang.

At least half a day until Huashan and Zhongnan arrive.

There was still plenty of time.

Once everything was ready, Murong Baek would meet the orthodox faction's reinforcements right here.

[3533] The Nine Springs is a traditional Chinese euphemism for the realm of the dead.

By then, he would have dealt with the Thunderbolt Saber King. The Hebei Peng Family martial artists beyond the gorge, now falling to the Murong Family's unexpected ambush, would be dead as well.

So would the people of Shanxi, slaughtering nomads on the far side of the suddenly collapsed cliff.

First, though, he must not forget the rats hiding beneath the earth, holding their breath.

Shhk.

His spearhead swept through like a streak of light, splitting a huge boulder and the mound of earth beneath it as easily as tofu.

Murong Baek looked down impassively at Jin Mukyung, who held the bloodied Cheol Mubaek and Wipeng in his arms.

Without a word, he brought his spear straight down.

No—he was about to.

Whoooom.

A tremendous rush of air sounded from somewhere, and Murong Baek turned his head on instinct.

He saw it.

KABOOOM!

A spear came crashing through, smashing apart the great mass of cliff rock in its path.

A blue-white flame burned along its icy, translucent spearhead.

Chapter 970

In the hazy darkness, unable to see an inch ahead, Jin Mukyung faced the only path left to him. He saw it not with his eyes, but with his heart.

A future that could never come to pass.

Eternal death.

So this is the end.

Even Jin Mukyung was surprised by how calmly he accepted it.

He'd already done everything he could.

He'd fought with all his strength, enough to look up at the heavens without a shred of shame. At last, that strength had run out.

Body and soul.

He'd poured everything into the fight. There was nothing left. In a world that had slowed to a crawl, he watched a spear rise and knew the death in its blade was drawing near, yet he couldn't twitch a finger.

And still, somewhere deep in his heart, one thread of regret remained. It was for the people he would leave behind.

What will happen to them now?

He didn't care what awaited him after death.

Even if a pale-faced Grim Reaper dressed head to toe in black appeared right now, bound him in chains, and dragged him before Yama,[3534] it wouldn't matter.

He had lived an honorable life as a martial artist and as the Jin Family of Taiyuan's Second Young Master. The lives he'd taken had been taken to protect others, not because he wanted to kill.

But now he had to leave.

He had to leave everyone behind and be dragged into the unknown darkness. Not by choice.

Everything he'd wanted to protect, everything he had ultimately failed to save, would remain here.

...No. Anything but that.

In that instant, Jin Mukyung clenched his teeth.

He forced his fading consciousness awake and screamed silently.

Everything I could? What did that even mean?

How could he accept death so weakly?

If he was still alive, it wasn't over. Not until his last breath.

He had to get up. He had to fight until his pounding heart stopped.

I—I...!

[3534] Yama is the lord and judge of the dead in Buddhist tradition.

His fingertips trembled. The smell of blood rose between his clenched teeth.

But even biting his own tongue couldn't rouse a body that had long since passed its limit. The cruel reality didn't change.

Whoosh.

The sound of something cutting through the air rang clearly in his ears. In his blurred vision, the slanting flash seemed unusually slow.

Slow enough to look back on his entire life.

Slow enough to picture the most infuriating face in the world.

If you were here instead of me… everything would be different.

As the spearhead fell toward his head, Jin Mukyung spoke in his heart to the only younger brother he had. The words would never reach him.

Looks like I won't be able to keep that promise after all.

Two years ago, the brothers had made a promise through the wall of the training hall.

They would meet at the Star-Array Grand Banquet, the gathering of countless stars that lit up the world.

In the end, Jin Mukyung hadn't kept his promise.

He'd been ashamed. His accomplishments had felt nowhere near enough.

When he'd first picked up a sword, he'd wanted to become a great martial artist. Later, he'd wanted to become the pride of the Jin Family of Taiyuan and a younger brother his elder brother could be proud of.

But there was another reason—his greatest reason—for spending the past two years swinging his sword without rest in suffocating darkness.

He wanted to be an older brother who could hold his head high.

He wanted to become strong enough to surpass the wall that was Cheongpung, so his younger brother, who'd become the Divine Dragon and soared freely through the sky, wouldn't be ashamed of him.

But…

So this is how it ends.

Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword.

The time of opportunity granted to a young genius, overshadowed by other monsters, was over.

The sword he'd honed in the dark had shone brightly enough to light this gorge today. But that fleeting light would be swallowed by the long, deep night.

Forever.

Damn it.

Jin Mukyung struggled to lift his half-closed eyelids.

He would not close his eyes in the face of death. It was the last pride he had as a martial artist, proof that his fighting spirit remained unbroken. And he wanted to

say goodbye to his troublesome younger brother, even if his voice would never reach him.

"…I'm sorry."

The words had barely left Jin Mukyung's lips when—

KABOOOOOM!

The sky and earth shook.

His world, dark and hazy until then, turned blue-white. The flash falling toward his head changed course and swept sideways.

Toward the terrible heat that had arrived faster than light, outrunning even the thunder of its arrival.

No—toward the spear carrying that heat.

Wooooom.

The wind vanished. The air stood still.

Two currents of qi met. In that instant, they enveloped everything within dozens of *zhang*,[3535] then swelled.

KRAAAAAASH!

A tremendous shock wave tore across the gorge, its roar deafening.

Lying in the deep pit, Jin Mukyung reached out on instinct. He held the unconscious Cheol Mubaek and Wipeng with all his strength and watched the corpses of people and horses, along with countless fragments of rock, fly in every direction as if caught in a storm.

Amid the blinding light that engulfed everything around him, he could just make out someone's back.

Jin Mukyung coughed up dark-red blood. A thought struck him.

Perhaps he was already dead. Perhaps his lingering attachment to life was making him see things even now.

But…

No.

Everything he saw, heard, and felt was too vivid to belong to the dead.

The stinging pain in his skin where the rock fragments had scraped past. The muscles screaming throughout his body. The blood surging from his insides, twisted by severe Internal Injury.

And, finally, the familiar voice that reached his ears.

"What are you throwing up for? Did you drink too much last night?"

Jin Mukyung's body went rigid.

His eyes flew wide, a storm raging in their depths.

There was no mistaking it. This wasn't a hallucination. He wasn't hearing things.

[3535] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *chi*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

This was…

"I'd pat you on the back, but, well, the situation's a little tricky."

The voice came through clearly as the roar died away.

In the fading light, he could see him.

That infuriating voice alone was enough to make Jin Mukyung want to raise a fist. That wastrel's back had, at some point, grown broader and sturdier than his own.

"You…!"

Where had the strength come from?

Jin Mukyung squeezed out a voice rough as scraping metal and raised his hand. Though his fingers shook like leaves, he reached toward his only younger brother's robe.

Rustle.

The sound of fabric brushing against something was so faint he had to strain to hear it.

Perhaps it was the wind, not Jin Mukyung's hand, that touched the edge of the tattered robe.

But that was enough.

What he wanted to convey was more than a touch. It was a desperate wish for his brother to protect everyone.

Thud.

His hand fell limply. His whole body went slack.

At last, the pathetic older brother, having spent every last bit of his strength, lost consciousness.

Before him stood his wastrel younger brother, returned after two years away. A dozen *zhang*[3536] from him stood an unfamiliar, graying middle-aged man, watching him with a dark, steady gaze.

"I have one question."

His eyes blazed with flame. His voice, by contrast, was cold as ice.

"Did you beat up my hyung?"[3537]

The wastrel had returned.

As a dragon whose roar shook the heavens.

Beyond his low voice rose the tearful cheers of the people of Shanxi.

Not long ago, someone told me not to carry everything alone.

To trust them a little more.

[3536] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *chi*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3537] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for his older brother or an older male he is close to.

Now I knew they'd been right.

I could tell the moment I reached the battlefield.

Blood was everywhere. Limbs torn from bodies I couldn't identify lay among countless corpses of people and horses. They had piled into small hills that filled the narrow gorge.

Most of the dead were nomads.

The enemy had outnumbered the people of Shanxi by at least two to one. They'd been badly outmatched in fighting strength, too. But they hadn't given in.

No. They'd fought back with every bit of strength they had.

The Imperial Army. The martial artists. Even ordinary people who probably hadn't learned a single move of martial arts.

And Jin Mukyung.

They did everything they could. Even when it meant overcoming their fear of death.

I knew how hard it was for the weak to stand against the strong.

And I'd taken Jin Mukyung's wish to heart. There could be no more sacrifices like theirs.

Wooooom. BOOM!

I reached out. With a thunderous crash, the spear buried deep in the cliff twisted like a living creature and flew toward me.

White Flame trembled faintly in my grasp, back from its brief journey.

The blue-white flames coiling around its blade lit the pitch-black darkness and heated the cold night air as they surged toward the enemy before me.

> **System** Lv.??? Murong Baek

A graying, middle-aged man stood before me, gripping a dark spear much like the charging spears the nomads used.

I'd be lying if I said the System window I read with my razor-sharp Qi Sense hadn't caught me off guard. But the reality before my eyes was the truth.

I looked at the Family Head of the Murong Family, a man I'd heard of but never met.

Another blade Dark Heaven had hidden in the vast forest of the Central Plains' Murim.

The North Heaven Demon Lord.

"I asked you. Did you beat up my hyung?"[3538]

The North Heaven Demon Lord was silent for a moment.

"Well, now."

[3538] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for his older brother or an older male he is close to.

His gaze swept over me, and he gave a small sigh at the arrival of an uninvited guest.

“This complicates things. In more ways than one.”

I bet it was. In more ways than one.

I lifted my spearhead, ready to strike at any moment.

“Why so troubled? You’re making me worry.”

Why the Family Head of the Murong Family had become Dark Heaven’s lackey, or when, didn’t matter to me right now.

I had only one thing to do: take down Murong Baek, without a doubt the North Heaven Demon Lord, and the nomad behind him, standing there with a thoroughly stiff expression.

“So why not just crack your skull while we’re at it? Then it won’t hurt anymore.”

Step.

The North Heaven Demon Lord took a step forward and answered calmly.

“That’s a treatment I’ve never heard of.”

“I know more about medicine than you’d think. I picked up a thing or two watching the Divine Physician.”

“Maybe. Even so, I suspect that method would be a problem.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord looked at me with a clear gaze that seemed to see through everything, then added:

“Especially in your current condition.”

I wanted to deny it, but he was right.

I’d paid a price for crossing ten thousand *li*[3539] without proper sleep, meals, or time to circulate my qi.

So I answered without hesitation.

“Yeah. You’re right.”

Step.

The footsteps that had been steadily closing the distance suddenly stopped. The North Heaven Demon Lord furrowed his brow as he looked at me.

“What did you say?”

“I said you’re right. Honestly, like this, it’d be tough. Really tough.”

“What are you—”

His voice trailed off. I shrugged at the North Heaven Demon Lord, who was staring at me as if I were crazy.

“So I brought someone I know along while I was at it.”

Before the North Heaven Demon Lord could grasp what I meant, two sharp whistles swept through the air.

[3539] In this Chinese setting, a *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); ten thousand *li* is about 5,000 km (3,107 mi).

Chapter 971

Human senses provide far more information than you might imagine.

That was especially true of martial artists, whose five senses were incomparably sharper than those of ordinary people. Living by the law of the jungle, they honed those senses through brutal training until they could detect things happening far beyond what the naked eye could see.

Just as the North Heaven Demon Lord did now.

“So I brought someone I know along while I was at it.”

Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

Despite the overwhelming force of his arrival, the young upstart looked plainly exhausted. But the moment the North Heaven Demon Lord heard his easygoing voice, a red warning light went on in his head.

A title and a name sprang to mind.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

A giant who stood astride the orthodox and unorthodox factions. An old monster of Mount Jiuhua. And the master who had taken the wastrel Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan as his Disciple.

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes widened.

If that’s the case…

He was certain something had gone wrong. He didn’t know when or where, but it had.

Not every plan went exactly as intended. Still, Jin Taekyung and Jeok Cheongang were not supposed to be here.

Information leaked.

But he never got as far as wondering who had leaked it, or how.

More precisely, he wasn’t given the chance.

Whoosh! Whoooooom!

One sound was faint and swift. The other swept in like a furious gale.

The two streaks of sound reached him through senses that had gone beyond the five and into the sixth. The North Heaven Demon Lord furrowed his brow.

Not one. Two.

That mattered even more than the direction they had come from: the cliffs on either side, not the ground ahead.

KABOOOOOM!

A crash rang out from atop the cliffs, more than thirty *zhang*[3540] high. Horrific screams mingled with it.

[3540] A *zhang* is a traditional unit of length, here about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty *zhang* is about 91 m (300 ft).

It sounded like thunder.

Thunder that swallowed someone's life and summoned an untimely shower.

Drip. Drip-drip.

Beside the North Heaven Demon Lord, Jamukha stood silently looking up at the darkened cliff. Then he felt something hot land on his face.

Red, sticky blood.

"…!"

The corners of Jamukha's mouth trembled. The North Heaven Demon Lord's gaze darkened.

They both knew what it meant.

Annihilation.

The nomads they had sent up the cliff at considerable cost were gone. In a span too brief to call even a moment, every one of them had been killed or captured.

What mattered most to the North Heaven Demon Lord was the identity of the two monsters who had swept the cliff clear so quickly.

"One of them is obviously your master. Who's the other?"

At his dry question, the young monster—still a little green—put on a stern expression.

"Now, now. You should figure it out for yourself. What kind of upbringing did you have, trying to peek at the answer sheet at your age?"

For a moment, the North Heaven Demon Lord wanted to crack open Jin Taekyung's skull and take a look inside. But the monsters on the cliff would not even let him take a step.

Shwaa!

The narrow gorge lit up. The North Heaven Demon Lord swung the spear in his hand without hesitation, striking a streak of light hurtling through the air.

BOOM!

The crash was far too loud to have come from two blades meeting.

The flash ricocheted from the impact and buried itself deep in the ground. The North Heaven Demon Lord frowned as he recognized it.

"A charging spear?"

There was no doubt. It was an utterly ordinary charging spear of the sort the steppe nomads used.

Yet the strike had been so swift he could hardly believe someone had simply thrown it.

It was as if the spear had been shot like an arrow.

Wait. Could it be…?

The North Heaven Demon Lord looked up.

Just then, moonlight slipped through a break in the clouds, revealing a woman holding a bow so enormous it could have been mistaken for a long spear.

"…The Bow Saint."

The words left his lips like a groan.

At the same moment, flashes rained down again.

KABOOOM!

The bowstring moved at dazzling speed, each release ringing through the gorge. The Bow Saint fired a dozen or so charging spears as lightly as arrows, then slowly drew back the string.

Wooooom.

Space trembled.

Brilliant qi gathered along a silver line formed from internal energy, taking the shape of an arrow. Then it shot forth, charged with immense power.

Not toward the North Heaven Demon Lord, but toward other enemies.

FWOOSH!

The deep darkness tore open.

Everyone on the battlefield could see that dazzling, destructive flash.

The people of Shanxi, hacking their way through the enemies in the gorge with hoarse, unrelenting battle cries.

The nomads dying helplessly at their hands.

And the martial artists of the Hebei Peng Family, fighting desperately in the broad basin beyond the gorge while surrounded by nomads and the Murong Family.

"What in the world is that…?"

The Keshik centurion had only just spotted the dozen or so streaks of light raining down from the sky. He had no idea the bewildered words leaving his lips would be his last.

Nor that this would be the last sight he and hundreds of his comrades saw in this world.

KABOOOOOM!

The earth turned over with a terrifying crash.

Arms and legs flew up through fountains of blood, along with pieces of flesh and organs too mangled to recognize. They scattered in every direction.

Krrrsh. Splatter.

Blood and flesh pattered down onto the ground, their late arrival ringing in everyone's ears.

Peng Cheolyeong, Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family and the Iron Blood Saber, blinked blankly. The Murong Family's unexpected betrayal had left him surrounded on all sides and covered in blood.

What just happened?

He had been fighting dozens of enemies alone with his back to the gorge. He hadn’t seen a thing.

He had only sensed the sky brighten. A chill had run down his spine, and his hand had stopped on instinct.

And… that was all.

He shut his eyes against the brilliant light stabbing into them. When he opened them again, the enemies who had filled the space around him were gone.

No. To be precise, they were still there.

Just no longer in shapes that could be called human.

Some had lost their upper bodies. Others had limbs torn away.

“Ugh—aaah!”

“Graaaah!”

The body feels pain first, but the brain is what recognizes it.

As the survivors finally grasped the unbelievable reality, they let out desperate screams. Unlike the hundreds killed by the flash, those lucky enough to survive writhed in pain.

Before their horrific screams could die away, the sky lit up once more.

FWOOSH.

In that moment, Peng Cheolyeong understood.

That dazzling beam of light—something he would normally have stopped to stare at—meant death.

And that death was not meant for him or the martial artists of the Hebei Peng Family.

“Attack!”

Fear is contagious. Hope catches fire.

With the flash lighting up the blood- and corpse-covered basin behind them, the martial artists of the Hebei Peng Family surged forward, tearing apart the encirclement that had already crumbled.

Their fierce cries rang out across the battlefield, loud enough to echo all the way into the depths of the narrow gorge.

“Sounds nice. Not for you, though.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord silently watched Jin Taekyung’s smiling face.

For all the mischief in the young bastard’s voice, his eyes were dark and solemn. Reflected in them, the North Heaven Demon Lord saw his own face, stiff with tension.

The Bow Saint.

He had not anticipated her presence. She was a ghost from a past too distant to appear here.

“So that’s why you were so relaxed.”

After a brief silence, the North Heaven Demon Lord spoke again, the broad outline of what had happened finally falling into place.

“So it was the Imperial Palace.”

The Bow Saint’s appearance brought the scattered clues together.

Why Jin Taekyung had been able to come here. Whether Dark Heaven’s plan centered on the Imperial Capital had succeeded. And where the Bow Saint had taken refuge after vanishing without a trace.

“But how did you find out so quickly?”

“Your friend told me,” Jin Taekyung answered.

“My friend?”

“The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.”

“…!”

“You should’ve been friendlier with him. Had meals together more often, swapped catalog numbers[3541] like proper members of the martial world. Well, I’m just glad I found out before it was too late.”

Jin Taekyung shrugged with an irritating look on his face and added, “When you see him in a bit, thank him for me. He deserved to die, but at the end, I found myself a little concerned about him.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord understood what he meant and smiled bitterly.

“I’ll have to politely decline.”

“What, were you two that unfriendly? Was there a love triangle or something?”

“Crazy bastard. Does your tongue ever rest?”

“I was about to stop anyway. I can move a little now.”

The smile faded from Jin Taekyung’s lips.

He had already shaken off the weakness left by the strike he’d launched with all his strength to save Jin Mukyung, exhausted as he was.

“Thanks for waiting while I caught my breath.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord looked at him with a subdued gaze.

He had not given Jin Taekyung that time willingly. Someone else had forced him to.

“Enough of this. Why don’t you come out, Fire King?”

At his words to the empty air, a figure blended into the darkness drifted gently down.

“What a shame. If you’d taken so much as one step, I’d have burned your limbs off.”

“I wonder if you really could.”

[3541] The Korean term *pumbeon* means an adult video’s catalog number. Swapping numbers implies trading recommendations.

The North Heaven Demon Lord gripped his spear at an angle. Unprecedented qi surged along its blade—nothing like what Jeok Cheongang remembered from their encounter on a battlefield long ago.

“You’ve grown bold, haven’t you? A mere pup, speaking to this old man like an equal and even daring to act tough.”

Jeok Cheongang grinned, baring his teeth. White hellfire rippled over both his outstretched hands.

“When did you join forces with them?”

“What a strange thing. The two of you, who were like cats and dogs, asking me the same question here today.”

The smile vanished from Jeok Cheongang’s face.

He knew whom the North Heaven Demon Lord meant. He knew, too, that the man’s life hung by a thread.

“…My Disciple owes that Peng bastard a great debt. I’ll repay it with your life.”

“You can both go together—to the afterlife.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord answered calmly and tossed what he held into his mouth.

Slip.

A red pill dissolved against his tongue. At the same moment, Jin Taekyung’s spearhead flashed behind him.

Chapter 972

Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung.

Jin Taekyung and Jeok Cheongang.

The moment it began, Master and Disciple moved as one.

As their heat closed in on him in a single step, fierce enough to set his whole body ablaze, the North Heaven Demon Lord realized once more:

He had made the right choice.

To make this plan—which had gone wildly off course from what he'd expected—succeed, he had to use everything he'd been given as quickly as possible.

Fwoosh!

Hot. Everything before his eyes turned red.

As the world slowed, the North Heaven Demon Lord felt a heat that seemed to burn through his entire body.

But it wasn't only the power of the Fire Gate Divine Technique, passed down for more than three hundred years, that made him feel that way.

KABOOOOOM!

A tremendous roar, audible only to him, reverberated from deep within his body.

At the same time, the qi throughout his body surged.

Lava-hot energy raced through hundreds of acupoints, swelling and surging as if it might burst at any moment.

A colossal wave of power from a strange artifact he had never once used was tearing down part of the high, sturdy wall that had stood in his way.

Ah…!

The North Heaven Demon Lord groaned amid overwhelming pain and ecstasy.

Everything in his reddened field of vision—even things he couldn't see—felt slow and vivid.

The wind. The air. The qi within it.

And the two streams of flame rushing toward him, smashing everything in their path to pieces.

So this is what it feels like. This is what it is.

The North Heaven Demon Lord thought.

He felt he could almost understand the world the Heavenly Demon had seen as he ruled over the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples with martial prowess that reached the heavens and sought to conquer the world. The world the Martial God had seen when he defeated him and brought peace to it.

Perhaps that was why he could smile, even amid heat fierce enough to melt his Body-Protecting Qi.

Whoooom.

Perhaps that was why their movements looked so slow and weak.

Is that all you've got?

The view changed depending on where you stood.

Seized by the sensation that the Temporary Strength Pill had carried him over the summit and above the clouds, the North Heaven Demon Lord looked down on them with disdain.

His gaze swept over the entire battlefield beyond the narrow gorge, taking in even the old monster and the young Divine Dragon—men whose names alone could make the world tremble.

At the same time, he flung out both arms with a speed and power he had imagined countless times, yet had always felt as distant as a dream.

Fwoooosh!

Space warped under the unprecedented energy. A spearhead and a fist, their forms obscured beneath dark crimson Force, shot in different directions.

Toward the foolish descendants of the Fire Gate Clan, who had failed to recognize the power of an absolute being.

Die.

In the North Heaven Demon Lord's red-hot vision, Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung stared wide-eyed at the overwhelming power before them.

Dark crimson Force swept toward them like a wave.

KABOOOOOM!

The entire gorge shook. The shock wave swelled and exploded, sweeping everything within a radius of more than ten *zhang*[3542].

No—*seized* and *swallowed* would have been better words for it.

The blinding flash and thunderous roar robbed everyone in the gorge of sight and hearing. Everything within reach of the shock wave lost its shape and vanished.

Rrrrrumble!

Part of the cliff collapsed, unable to withstand the aftershock.

The pools of blood and countless corpses scattered all around had vanished into dust. Amid what remained, the North Heaven Demon Lord drew a slow breath.

He shuddered at the power still welling up from deep inside him after that outburst—and at the fact that he had unleashed a calamity like a natural disaster with his own two hands.

Then he turned his head toward somewhere beyond the choking silence and clouds of dust.

No—he sensed them.

[3542] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The presences that had survived this horrific disaster, not yet entirely extinguished.

“You managed to survive. As you should have.”

His voice was calm and relaxed.

The Temporary Strength Pill had given him martial prowess far beyond what he’d possessed only moments ago. Still, he had never expected to win with a single strike.

His opponent was the old monster of Mount Jiuhua, returned stronger than he’d been fifty years ago. And his Disciple had grown beyond a young prodigy into a towering figure who was leaving his mark on this vast world.

Even so, the North Heaven Demon Lord could remain at ease. He knew better than anyone the scale of the power throbbing within him, ready to burst.

Even if someone else intervened, that wouldn’t change.

As someone did now.

Whoom! KABOOM!

In the blink of an eye, a mass of concentrated energy struck the spearhead the North Heaven Demon Lord had swung, bouncing off from an unseen blind spot.

The North Heaven Demon Lord looked up at the figure standing atop a fractured, crumbling cliff more than thirty *zhang*[3543] high. A faint smile touched his lips.

“You’ve had a rough time, Bow Saint.”

Deflecting that attack confirmed it for him once more: his martial prowess now surpassed that of the Three Saints.

He had set foot, if only by one step, into the realm of those called the Invincible—or the absolute.

KRAKAKAKANG!

A mass of light packed with such tremendous power it could hardly be called an arrow.

The North Heaven Demon Lord deflected a barrage of them, each powerful enough to kill even a skilled Peak master with one strike. His smile deepened.

“You should’ve come a little slower. If you’d taken your time and saved some strength, a lot might have turned out differently.”

The distance from Zhejiang Province, where the Imperial Capital stood, to Shanxi Province was well over a few thousand *li*[3544].

And for those three to have crossed that distance and appeared here without catching the North Heaven Demon Lord’s attention meant they’d moved faster than a messenger eagle or a courier.

[3543] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3544] A Chinese *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

They had rushed here without sparing even a moment, let alone taking proper rest before a battle.

That guess was enough to convince the North Heaven Demon Lord that victory was certain.

“Unfortunately, it’s too late to turn back now.”

Shhhh…

Dark crimson energy rose from his whole body like heat haze.

As the Bow Saint’s attacks bounced off his densely concentrated Force, exhilaration swept through him more intensely than ever before.

An absolute being.

Here, today, he was the absolute being.

The Fire Gate Clan’s Master and Disciple, who must be lying beyond that cloud of dust, groaning, could not stand against him now. Neither could the Bow Saint.

They were all exhausted, while his power continued to well up without end.

Crack.

A deep rumble spread from the tip of his foot as he stepped forward lightly.

The colossal power had frozen everyone in the gorge.

An unprecedented energy no one had ever imagined a human could possess expanded his dantian and raced through hundreds of acupoints.

The North Heaven Demon Lord laughed aloud.

It feels like I could do anything right now.

No—he *could*.

And just as his senses stretched out to envelop the entire gorge—

“Old Master, that bastard’s laughing.”

“Leave him be. He must think he’s the Lord of Heaven just because he took a Temporary Strength Pill.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s smile vanished. Two voices were conversing through Sound Transmission inside the dust cloud that had yet to settle.

“Uh, he’s not laughing anymore.”

“He was ugly to begin with, but now he’s scowling. His face looks like shit.”

“Why would you say it like that? My little guy is handsome and looks plenty clever.”

“All right, I get it. Take your damn hand off your waistband right now, before I turn you into a eunuch with one palm strike.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s gaze darkened. Confusion and shock unmistakable in his eyes, he looked in one direction.

“Uh, he’s looking this way.”

“Must’ve just gotten lucky. This old man knows at a glance.”

“We need to jump him all at once. What if he’s spotted us? Try moving to the side.”

“I was about to. Stop pushing me. How dare you touch this old man’s body?”

“That’s not a hand.”

“Huh?”

At that moment, the North Heaven Demon Lord’s mouth twitched.

“Come out.”

At the low words that slipped between his lips, a breathless silence descended.

Seemed to.

“He says come out. And he’s looking right at us.”

“Didn’t I tell you? He definitely guessed.”

“I don’t think so. Wait, can he hear our Sound Transmission?”

“Just because he took some pill? There’s no way that bastard can do that. I’ll stake that Hyuk bastard’s balls on it.”

Tap.

The last thread of the North Heaven Demon Lord’s patience broke. A cold voice slipped through his clenched teeth.

“What a shame. I don’t know who he is, but he’s going to lose his balls.”

At last, he received the answer he’d been waiting for.

Poom!

The dust cloud split as if cut by a sword. Jeok Cheongang emerged in tattered clothes, brushed the dirt from his shoulder, and replied, “That’s fine. Just in case, I didn’t stake my own.”

Behind the Master, who had said something so embarrassing with an unnecessarily solemn expression, his Disciple—several heads taller—spoke with an uneasy look.

“Why stake the balls of someone who isn’t even here? You won’t need them anyway. You might as well stake your own.”

“Isn’t that true of you, too?”

“Hey, that’s crossing a line. Why would you say—”

KABOOM!

A thunderous crash swallowed the rest of his words.

A moment later came a cough.

“Cough. Jeez, look at all this fine dust. Wouldn’t want anyone thinking you’re not a Chinese bastard.”

“Ahem. Stop making a fuss. You’ll bring shame on the Fire Gate Clan.”

“My God, is there even more shame left to bring?”

At the sight of Jin Taekyung and Jeok Cheongang standing there unharmed, the North Heaven Demon Lord’s gaze darkened.

How…?

He hadn’t attacked at full power, but they had evaded a strike backed by more than seventy percent of his strength. They clearly still had plenty in reserve.

The North Heaven Demon Lord had no choice but to admit that, at some point, he’d come to trust too much in the power he’d been given.

And that he had underestimated the enemies before him.

“Jamukha.”

At his quiet call, the hunting dog he had commanded for decades answered.

“Give your command, my lord.”

“We won’t stand by any longer. Change the plan.”

“You mean…”

“I will not tolerate any more interference. Before things go wrong, use every force we have and wipe them out at once.”

Jamukha understood exactly what the North Heaven Demon Lord meant by using every last bit of their strength.

Today, the Thunderbolt Saber King and the Hebei Peng Family had been invited guests on this battlefield. The three Supreme Peak masters who had appeared unexpectedly, however, were uninvited.

The die had been cast. They had to secure victory before the whole game was overturned.

As the North Heaven Demon Lord had just done, they would use every means at their disposal.

“As you command.”

With that curt reply, Jamukha pulled a signal flare from his robes and yanked its cord without hesitation.

Fwish! Fwish! Fwish!

Smoke shot up into the night.

The Bow Saint swiftly fired arrows of light that swept away most of it, but even she could do nothing about the wisps that scattered through the air.

Poom! Poom! Poom!

Fireworks blossomed across the blackened sky.

Obeying his master’s command, Jamukha had let the countless hunting dogs under him off their leashes. Now he tipped into his mouth the Temporary Strength Pill the North Heaven Demon Lord had stopped him from taking earlier.

Beyond the gorge, the Keshiks who had just seen the signal did the same.

Swish. Shhhh…

Red heat haze began to rise across the battlefield.

Chapter 973

The word *unavoidable* applied to everyone.

To farmers who faced drought before the harvest. To the sick who lay in bed, waiting for death to draw closer by the moment.

And to a woman whose astonishing power made it hard to believe she was human like them.

I should have stopped them.

The Bow Saint let out a low groan.

High atop a sheer cliff, she stared down at a group spewing streams of ghastly blood-red light.

Shhk! Krrrunch!

Every one of them had bloodshot eyes. A thick mist of blood gathered in the wake of their spears and blades as they advanced without hesitation.

On a battlefield where tens of thousands clashed, two hundred people were only a handful. But the Temporary Strength Pills had pushed each of them beyond their limits, making them more dangerous than any other enemy there.

Especially to the Hebei Peng Family's fighters, of whom only about two thousand remained.

Graaaah!

A harrowing scream rang through the night air.

As the enemy finally broke the Hebei Peng Family's vaunted Linked Tyrant King Formation, the Bow Saint lowered her drawn bow and bit her lip.

They were not only dangerous. They were clever.

After suffering heavy losses from several of her attacks, they had immediately spread out and plunged into the heart of her allies' formation to guard against any more.

If I keep attacking like this, I'll hit our own people too.

Even apart from the two hundred or so Keshiks, she had more than enough enemies to deal with.

The vast steppe army seemed endless, no matter how many she killed. The battle had already gone on for several *shichen*[3545], and the steppe forces had surely suffered far greater losses than the people of Shanxi. Yet nearly twenty thousand of them remained.

If she held the high ground and rained arrows down until she had no strength left, she could inflict tremendous damage. That much was obvious.

But she had only one choice.

[3545] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of about two hours.

To gain one thing was to lose another. If she kept attacking, she could bring down countless enemies—but by then, every last fighter of the Hebei Peng Family would be dead.

Her mind was made up. There was no need to hesitate.

I have to go. I have to do it myself.

Click.

She twisted her enormous bow with a sharp wrench, revealing two strangely shaped curved blades.

Their cool grips settled into her hands. The Bow Saint kicked off the cliff and soared into the sky.

Whoosh.

The cold night wind swept over her, setting her long hair streaming behind her.

She stepped through the empty air toward the ground as though descending an invisible staircase. Then she turned to look behind her.

The narrow gorge lay hidden in darkness now, its depths awash with waves of powerful qi. To someone there, she said silently:

Survive. Then prove yourself once more.

The Chosen One.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

His name weighed heavily on her heart as the Bow Saint plunged toward the distant ground.

Shwaa!

The two curved blades in her hands became razor-sharp winds, carving through space.

The Bow Saint was gone.

She had crossed to the other battlefield beyond the gorge—not to help Jeok Cheongang and me, but to aid the Hebei Peng Family's fighters.

I watched her disappear across the distant sky without feeling hurt that she'd left. Jeok Cheongang met my eyes and simply nodded, his expression calm.

Someone else here felt differently, of course.

"I expected as much, but it still amazes me."

The North Heaven Demon Lord spoke up without warning and went on without waiting for a reply.

"Why do you people always make such foolish choices? Every single time."

He shook his head with a hollow laugh. I answered calmly.

“Of course you’d think that. Bastards like you wouldn’t understand even if you died and came back dozens of times.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord thought of his followers as nothing more than pawns to secure victory. He could never understand that all of us here were risking our lives not to kill someone, but to protect someone.

Or that this small difference was the most important measure of what separated the righteous from the demonic.

“What a rotten age. The Murong Family Head goes and stabs someone in the back, then starts popping pills the moment things get a little rough. Right?”

Jeok Cheongang answered me.

“Live long enough, and you’ll meet things worse than beasts. Creatures wearing human skin and pretending to be people, hiding their black hearts behind pretty words and smiles.”

His voice was cold. His eyes burned.

At that moment, all his anger was directed at the North Heaven Demon Lord.

“I used to think you just had a sly streak… If I’d known it would come to this, I should have killed you back then.”

To me, he was the North Heaven Demon Lord. To Jeok Cheongang, he was Murong Baek.

Unlike me, Jeok Cheongang had known him. They had once fought alongside each other as comrades. Now their gazes met across the air.

“Why didn’t you, Fire King? That was your first and last chance to kill me.”

Jeok Cheongang’s eyes darkened at the mocking reply.

“First and last? Do you truly believe that?”

“You don’t?”

Rrrrumble.

The space around us shook as though an earthquake had struck. A mighty aura rose from the North Heaven Demon Lord, pressing down on everything around him.

An unprecedented surge of qi, rougher and greater than Jeok Cheongang’s.

“I’ll show you now. You’ll never get a second chance.”

His low words reached everyone’s ears, and the North Heaven Demon Lord vanished.

Swish.

He moved faster than the faint whistle of air left in his wake.

But I could see him, if only faintly. No—I could *sense* him.

The North Heaven Demon Lord shot forward faster than sound. His spearhead cut through space, and his loyal hunting dog rushed after its master.

Shwaa!

A belated gust of wind followed the descending spearhead.

I swung White Flame up toward the flash driving at my upper body.

BANG!

The roar hardly sounded as though it had come from two spears colliding.

Tremendous pressure traveled down White Flame's shaft to my toes. The ground split into a spiderweb of cracks.

Beyond the spearhead I had stopped, I met the North Heaven Demon Lord's eyes for an instant. I could almost hear the question in them.

How can a brat like you…?

I knew that look all too well.

The eyes gone wide. The question mark in them.

And every enemy I'd faced had found an exclamation point in its place before that question had even faded.

Just like now.

Ka-drrrk!

I gritted my teeth and drove my spear shaft upward.

The muscles throughout my body swelled as if they were about to burst. A power no one but me could understand—supernatural powers—surged up and shook off the tremendous pressure bearing down on the spearhead.

KABOOOOOM!

The North Heaven Demon Lord's eyes widened as the force drove him back.

That was when the hunting dog, arriving a step behind its master, bared its teeth.

Shwaek!

Before the dust kicked up by the shock wave could rise, a blade split through it.

The curved blade flashed through space toward the crown of my head. Just as it was about to strike, the air behind me blazed with heat.

Fwoosh.

A terrible heat. Merely touching it felt as though it would melt flesh and bone and burn even the soul.

Flame Divine Palm.

The instant I felt that familiar energy swell, I ducked without hesitation.

Paaang!

A mass of concentrated flame skimmed past the back of my head.

I looked up again, the back of my head burning as though scorched. The old nomad who had brought his curved blade down like a wild beast was already hurtling backward.

Krrrunch!

His feet gouged deep furrows in the ground. He was driven back nearly three *zhang*[3546] before Jeok Cheongang sniffed in his direction.

"Damn it. I was wondering where that horse shit smell was coming from. Turns out it was this barbarian."

"…!"

"That's quite a face you're making. What, now that you've had a taste of the heat, are you homesick for a steppe full of horse shit and weeds?"

Style may be temporary, but class is forever.

The old nomad's face went rigid under Jeok Cheongang's inspired verbal assault. Then a low voice rang out.

"Still the same. That tongue of yours still knows how to get under people's skin."

The remark was aimed at Jeok Cheongang, but the North Heaven Demon Lord's gaze was fixed on me.

Jeok Cheongang tapped my shoulder.

"When it comes to running his mouth, this brat is several steps ahead of this old man."

"He's surpassed his Master in all the wrong ways."

Jeok Cheongang gave a quiet laugh.

"Come now. You know it isn't just that."

The North Heaven Demon Lord said nothing. He looked at me as though he couldn't make sense of what he was seeing.

Honestly, that was only natural.

It wasn't just him. Anyone would have felt the same.

The Blood Lord, the Western Heaven Demon Lord, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord—and the other enemies I'd faced.

None of them had been able to make sense of me. None had found an answer, and the question had only grown with time.

No. More accurately…

I'd gotten that much stronger.

Looking back, every battle I'd fought over the last two years had been hard. My enemies were always strong, and I was always weaker than they were. I'd had to struggle with everything I had just to survive. Just to win.

But then, one day, I suddenly realized something.

I kept finding myself at death's door not because I was weak, but because stronger enemies kept appearing.

And somewhere along the way, I'd started catching up to them.

[3546] A *zhang* is a traditional length unit. Three *zhang* are roughly 9–10 m (30–33 ft).

The Head Elder, whose martial prowess had been so mighty. Pung Yang, whom I'd barely managed to defeat in a joint attack with Jin Mukyung.

The Demon Lords and Demon Empresses of Dark Heaven, each of them a nightmare in their own right.

Whenever I thought back on those battles that had brought me close to death, one thought would come to me:

Back then—if I'd moved like this, I could've won so much more easily.

Now I understood.

What I'd taken for regret and lingering misgivings was proof that I'd grown. It wasn't just a change in the numbers on the System window. I'd grown as a martial artist.

And maybe I was still growing, even now.

"Hey. This is just something I'm personally curious about."

I spoke up out of nowhere, then carefully put my question to the North Heaven Demon Lord.

Like a student asking a professor about a difficult assignment.

"Just now, wouldn't kicking you in the balls have been a lot better than knocking your spear up?"

The professor's face twisted beyond description.

Chapter 974

Sometimes, your true feelings just don’t get through to the other person.

It was sad to cause a misunderstanding I’d never intended, but there was nothing I could do about it.

We weren’t going to settle this by talking anyway.

“That mouth of yours…”

The words died before he could finish, leaving only a breath that scattered into the air.

The professor—or rather, the North Heaven Demon Lord—looked dizzy with rage. His face twisted as he steadied his breathing.

Since he seemed to be struggling, I spoke for him.

“I’ll tear it open.”

“What?”

“That’s what you were going to say, right? I’ve heard it plenty of times. I know.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord stared at me, momentarily at a loss for words, then clenched his teeth.

“Shut up.”

“Come on. A man has to say what’s on his mind. Even a shameless pill-popping bastard.”

“I said shut up.”

“But I’ve heard that line so many times, it feels a little stale. ‘I’ll tear your mouth open so you can never wag that unruly tongue again.‘ Doesn’t that have more flavor?”

“Words truly are wasted on you.”

“Force won’t work either. The guys who said that to me and died could line up in formation, count off, and circle the Murim Alliance training ground twice.”

Jeok Cheongang, standing beside me, added, “For the record, mine would circle it more than ten times.”

“That’s because you’ve lived a lot longer than me.”

“If you don’t like it, live a long, healthy life yourself.”

“You’ve lived a long, sickly life. Don’t you remember? When I first met you…”

Fwoosh!

A sharp whistle swallowed the rest of my words.

I ducked on instinct, without a moment’s hesitation. A dagger shot past overhead at the speed of a streak of light and slammed into the cliff face.

KABOOM!

It struck with the force of a cannonball.

But no matter how much power an attack carried, it didn't matter if it missed.

I brushed off the grit thrown up by the shock wave and stared wide-eyed at the North Heaven Demon Lord, who had thrown the dagger.

"Wow. That almost hit me."

"…!"

"Those pills really do make you strong. Old Master, I'd never beat him one-on-one."

Jeok Cheongang frowned. "Was that even a question? Of course you wouldn't. Keep going as you have been, though, and in another year or two at the earliest, you might have a chance."

Only a year or two.

Jeok Cheongang knew my past and even my deepest secrets, so it was a fairly reasonable assessment. To someone listening, though, it was an intolerable insult.

"Jamukha."

There was no anger left on the North Heaven Demon Lord's face. At his low voice, the old nomad bowed his head.

"Give your command, my lord."

"Do you remember the promise we made long ago?"

"I have never forgotten it for a single moment."

"Then stake your life on it."

"…!"

"If you survive, I'll give you Hebei along with the vast grasslands. Everything the Peng Family possessed—even their lives—I'll put in your hands."

The old nomad Jamukha's eyelids trembled.

"That is the very reason I have lived until now."

"Then what will you give me?"

"Today's victory, and the head of Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon."

"Yes. That is the answer I wanted."

Step. Shhhhh…

With a heavy step, the dark crimson energy that had risen like heat haze gathered into a thick mist.

The two men had finally drawn out every last drop of their strength. Watching them, Jeok Cheongang spoke calmly.

"Taekyung."

"Yes?"

"Do you remember the promise we made long ago?"

I answered without hesitation. "No."

"…"

"And what do you mean, 'long ago'? It's only been two years since we first met."

Jeok Cheongang fell silent for a moment, then sighed.

“Do you have some kind of disease that makes blood gush from your seven apertures[3547] and kills you if you play along at a time like this?”

“What’s the point? We can’t even get our timing right. Better to land another hit on those bastards.”

“Hmm. Hard to argue with that.”

“Just do what you’ve always done. Be the Fire King.”

Jeok Cheongang’s gaze shifted from the North Heaven Demon Lord and Jamukha, who were approaching slowly and cautiously, to me.

“What? Is there something else you want to say?”

“No, nothing much. It just struck me that accepting you as my Disciple was the right choice.”

For a moment, I didn’t know what to say. Then Jeok Cheongang’s quiet voice reached my ear.

“We’ve never made any embarrassing promises to each other, but as always, remember one thing.”

“What should I keep in mind…?”

“This old man is always by your side.”

“…!”

“So don’t do anything stupid like fighting to the death. Even if Yama[3548] comes for you, I’ll kick him in the ass and send him packing.”

The more I thought about it, the stranger it seemed.

People were all made of the same flesh and blood. How could they think so differently?

One person offered another everything he wanted in exchange for his life. Another asked for nothing—he only wanted the other person to survive.

And that was exactly what I wanted to say to Jeok Cheongang, too.

“If I keep that promise, what will you give me?”

Step by step, the two enemies drew closer. I watched the dark crimson mist grow thicker as I spoke, and Jeok Cheongang gave a dry laugh.

“You shameless bastard. Fine, what do you want?”

“Nothing much. You’ve already been sick once, so a long, healthy life is out of the question. Just make sure you live a long, sickly one from now on.”

“A long life at my age, huh? Seems I have a reason to live at least another hundred years.”

Jeok Cheongang laughed heartily, clearly delighted.

[3547] In traditional East Asian usage, the seven apertures are the eyes, ears, nostrils, and mouth.

[3548] Yama is the Buddhist lord of the underworld, associated with judgment of the dead.

Pale light-flames gathered in his outstretched hands. Alongside them, blue-white flames surged over the spearhead of White Flame, burning away the chill of the deep night.

Fwoooosh.

Beyond the darkness melting before those two flames—alike, yet different—

I stepped toward the ominously thick dark crimson mist.

No. *We* stepped forward together, as if we'd promised to.

Shwaa!

Everyone who faced that mist, red as blood and frighteningly thick, felt a chill sink deep into their spines and stopped.

No. They had no choice but to stop.

Their instincts knew before their minds did.

If I get close, I'll die.

The sight alone was chilling.

The qi hanging thick in the air had become almost tangible. Entering it would be like walking into a forest of blades and spears, ready to slice and tear their bodies apart.

But the greatest reason so many people from Shanxi were held back was the terrifying battle raging inside it.

KABOOM! KABOOOOM!

What could describe the scene better than *heaven and earth shaking*?

Beyond the mist, writhing like a living creature, four Supreme Peak masters were entangled with one another at the speed of flashes of light.

Without a moment's pause.

Even now.

Shhk!

Force sliced through the hard ground as if it were tofu.

Jeok Cheongang narrowly dodged the North Heaven Demon Lord's strike and clenched his fist.

Pale light-flames surged over the fist of a man whose regained youth had erased his wrinkles.

Fwoosh!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

A tremendous blaze erupted from a technique he had brought to the tenth level of mastery through more than a century of training.

It stained the air and shot toward the enemy before him—toward the North Heaven Demon Lord.

KABOOOOOM!

Compressed air exploded in layers.

The ground melted and the cliff walls shook, but at the last instant, the North Heaven Demon Lord's figure blurred and vanished.

Or rather, it vanished from human sight, with all its limitations.

Whoosh.

A tiny, faint whistle slipped quietly into his ear.

But he knew well that movement faster than sound could fool his hearing, too.

Above!

He felt it.

His opponent's presence, plunging down from the unseen space above his head.

And the immense Force riding the spearhead as it thrust forward, erasing the wind in its path.

Poom!

Jeok Cheongang struck out with both palms without hesitation.

The dark crimson mist surrounding them scattered in an instant.

Flame Divine Palm, unleashed at full strength, surged upward as a pillar of fire.

It raced toward an opponent who had tried to hide his presence, but whose immense energy made it impossible to conceal himself completely.

And in the next moment, Jeok Cheongang understood all over again.

With the Temporary Strength Pill's power behind him, the North Heaven Demon Lord could look down on even Jeok Cheongang—who had reached his current realm through several moments of enlightenment—as half a step beneath him.

Shwaa!

The spearhead pierced a single precise point.

The immense Force at its tip split flames that had seemed capable of burning the whole world, and the distance between the two men vanished.

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened at the overwhelming force.

This wasn't a question of enlightenment in the martial arts.

The North Heaven Demon Lord's movements, enhanced to an extreme, made everything possible—along with internal energy so powerful it made Jeok Cheongang wonder if he had drawn out every last bit of his innate qi.

Damn it.

Swallowing the curse rising to his lips, Jeok Cheongang drew on all the internal energy in his body.

He slammed both hands together against the spearhead plunging toward his chest.

Krrrrk!

The spearhead trembled between his palms, pressed together as if in prayer.

Dark crimson Force tore into flesh and bone despite his Body-Protecting Qi. Jeok Cheongang clenched his teeth against the pain.

Crack.

The pain of breaking a molar was nothing beside what came from his hands as they grew more mangled by the second.

Jeok Cheongang swallowed the blood rising in his throat and held fast to the spearhead. The North Heaven Demon Lord bared his teeth in a grin.

“Why not stop now and get some rest? You look exhausted.”

Jeok Cheongang’s reply came through clenched teeth, edged with mockery.

“Right back at you.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes darkened.

He could feel throughout his body that Jeok Cheongang wasn’t bluffing.

What kind of monster is this old man?

Crack. Krrrunch.

Though he drove it with all his strength, the spearhead could go no farther.

Jeok Cheongang’s skin was crushed by the Force, but his toes were dug deep into the ground, perfectly still.

The old monster of Mount Jiuhua had returned decades younger—and far stronger than the North Heaven Demon Lord remembered.

Strong enough that even after taking the Temporary Strength Pill, he couldn’t bring him down easily.

But…

It ends here.

The moment that thought formed, the North Heaven Demon Lord twisted the spear shaft with every ounce of strength he had.

This time, even Jeok Cheongang would be unable to bear the pain.

Crack.

At the grisly sound of flesh tearing, Jeok Cheongang’s body shuddered. Then a thunderous shout burst from Jamukha’s lips.

“Jamukha!”

At that instant—

KABOOM! Shhk!

With a thunderous crash, a razor-sharp gust of wind shot toward Jeok Cheongang’s back.

Chapter 975

No matter how well trained a hunting dog was, it couldn't take down a predator on its own.

There was no getting around the difference between what they had been born to be.

But Jamukha was different. Born a predator, he had become a hunting dog to achieve his own ends.

He was a trained beast, with both the strength to face any enemy and the loyalty of a hunting dog.

That was why, the moment he heard his master call, he could spring into action without a second's hesitation.

"Jamukha!"

The signal he'd been waiting for had barely sounded when Jamukha swung his curved blade with all his might.

BOOM!

Two waves of Force collided in midair.

The dark green Force of his blade, made darker and larger by the effects of the Temporary Strength Pill, pushed back the blue-white flames, if only for a moment. Just then, Jamukha's foot shot forward like an arrow.

Whoosh.

His figure blurred.

Using Shifting Form and Position in that fleeting instant, Jamukha became a streak of wind and crossed more than ten *jang*[3549].

He raced toward the Fire King—a predator more ferocious and powerful than any quarry he'd ever faced.

One strike. One strike is all it takes.

There was near-certainty in Jamukha's movements, and it was no baseless boast.

For more than fifty years, he had pursued speed above all else, honing his martial arts to counter the Hebei Peng Family's overbearing style.

Jamukha had no doubt that even Jin Taekyung, called the Divine Dragon, had his limits. He couldn't make up for all those years of difference.

And besides…

With this power, I can do anything.

Everything had changed. Like a caterpillar shedding a layer and being born anew, he saw the whole world afresh.

[3549] A *jang* is ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

His feet, skimming over the ground, and the beloved weapon gripped in both hands felt lighter than ever.

The Temporary Strength Pill had drawn his power beyond its limits. Even now, that power seethed ceaselessly deep within him.

His sixth sense, awakened beyond the five, let him easily evade even the streak of flame bearing down on him from behind.

Shweeeee!

Jamukha picked up speed and turned his head. A spearhead that had left Jin Taekyung's hand tore through the air, grazed the back of his neck, and buried itself in the cliff face.

KABOOM!

Sharp fragments of rock flew in every direction. Jamukha leaped over the rising cloud of dust and raced on, his figure seeming to erase the wind.

I'll bring him down. No matter what.

Jamukha's resolve wasn't a hunting dog's loyalty to its master.

No—he couldn't have called it loyalty from the start.

It hadn't come from his heart. The other man's strength and his own ambitions had simply come together to force him into submission.

But that was enough.

Even if his loyalty was feigned, the North Heaven Demon Lord had promised him a sure reward. Dark Heaven had enough power to make him king of the steppe and ruler of the north.

And now, Jamukha's mighty downward slash was bringing him one step closer to that grand ambition.

Shwack.

In the slowed world, Jeok Cheongang still had his back to him, seemingly unable to react at all. He remained locked in combat with the North Heaven Demon Lord, his back utterly exposed.

Dark green Force, arriving before its own sound, filled Jamukha's eyes.

It's over.

Jamukha was certain.

No one could dodge this strike.

Even if his opponent was the giant known as the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, the outcome would be the same: death.

But it took only an instant for that certainty, which had risen like an exclamation point, to turn into a question mark.

Fwoosh.

A terrible heat suddenly washed over him from behind.

At the same time, someone's fingertips flashed out and touched Jamukha's long hair, braided into a queue in the custom of the steppe.

No—by the time he felt them touch it, his head was already being wrenched backward.

Grab.

A hand seized his hair with brutal force. His upper body bent back, and his curved blade wavered off course.

Through the sudden pain and shock, Jamukha understood why Jeok Cheongang hadn't even turned his head in the face of such danger.

It wasn't that he couldn't react.

There was no doubt about it.

Jeok Cheongang had known from the beginning.

No—he had trusted him.

His one and only Disciple.

His Disciple's might, something no number of years could measure.

Whoosh!

The dark green Force skimmed past Jeok Cheongang's head by a hair and slashed through empty air.

As Jamukha clenched his teeth against the pain and frustration, a quiet voice reached his ear.

"Nice braid."

"…!"

"Looks easy to rip right off."

Krrk, krrrunch!

The world before Jamukha's eyes turned white.

The pain of having his hair and scalp torn off together drew a silent scream from him. He spun around and swung his curved blade.

Whoooosh!

The dark green Force hadn't died out despite his terrible pain. If anything, it surged more fiercely, tearing through space.

A blade technique perfected over more than half a century in pursuit of ultimate speed.

But Jamukha had no idea.

More precisely, he could never have imagined it.

The strength and speed with which he had subdued the vast steppe in a flash fell short of the enlightenment and rewards Jin Taekyung had gained over the past two years, crossing the line between life and death again and again.

Poom!

Flame Divine Palm.

The tremendous blaze swept in, burning even the air. Jamukha's upper body lurched. Unimaginable heat burned through the acupoints all over his body and ravaged them.

Ah.

As his vision faded, Jamukha swallowed the blood surging up from deep in his dantian.

But even after taking that horrifically powerful strike, he could still feel a spark of hope that hadn't gone out.

The Temporary Strength Pill.

A source of power that kept welling up.

The vitality holding his body together when it should have crumpled long ago.

Not yet. Not yet…!

Jamukha gritted his teeth.

With all his might, he tightened his grip on the hilt as it began to slip from his hand and drove the blade down toward Jin Taekyung's chest.

Ka-drrk, crack!

Two opposing sounds mingled in midair.

And then—

"Ah, that hurts like hell."

Jin Taekyung was drenched in dark red blood and groaning in pain. Staring at him, Jamukha forced out a question.

"How…?"

His voice broke apart like stepping-stones in a stream.

He couldn't understand it.

Setting everything else aside, he genuinely wanted to know.

How had Jin Taekyung blocked that strike?

What kind of sorcery had made red-tinged armor appear over the bare skin showing through his tattered clothes just moments ago?

"This… *cough*, this doesn't make—"

Krrrunch.

His voice scattered in a silent scream.

Twisting the five fingers he had driven into Jamukha's flank like a hook, Jin Taekyung answered with a tired look.

"Why couldn't we just make this easy? Why'd you have to keep hanging on? I was saving this for later."

What did he mean?

How was any of this possible?

His questions unanswered, Jamukha tightened his grip as if in a daze.

He had forgotten that the Force once surging like waves had died away, and that his once razor-sharp blade had gone dull.

Scrape. Clang.

The curved blade never pierced Fire Dragon Armor. As if clinging to its owner's regret, it scraped across the armor's surface before slipping from his hand.

Poom.

With another burst of heat from Flame Divine Palm, Jamukha heard an explosion deep inside his body.

"Guh—!"

His vision dimmed. His ears went muffled.

Everything felt strange, as if it belonged to someone else.

Distant, as though he were watching from hundreds of *ri*[3550] away.

The heat of the blood spilling from his lips. The shout that could only have come from the North Heaven Demon Lord.

And yet one thing remained vivid.

The blows that kept pounding and breaking his body.

Poom. Poom. Pooom.

Jamukha staggered. Even as that terrifying force battered him, he couldn't take a single step back.

Through pain so intense it felt as if his soul were burning white, the five fingers buried in his flank held him fast like a hook.

One punch, one palm strike—each carrying terrifying power—filled his vision, raining down in a blue-white torrent.

Until everything the Temporary Strength Pill had given him was spent.

Until that vast sea of power, which had seemed as though it would spring forth forever, ran dry.

And at some point, Jamukha realized he could no longer feel pain.

Thud.

Like a leaf falling at the end of autumn, Jamukha crumpled.

His eyes moved weakly upward. Reflected in them were the endless dark night sky and Jin Taekyung, standing tall as a giant.

You… You're…

What are you?

Before he could finish the thought, Jamukha's world tilted.

Thud.

Heat rose in a wavering haze. Jin Taekyung looked down at the king of the steppe, blackened and lifeless, then let out the breath he had been holding.

[3550] A Korean *ri* is about 393 m (0.244 mi).

Hoo.

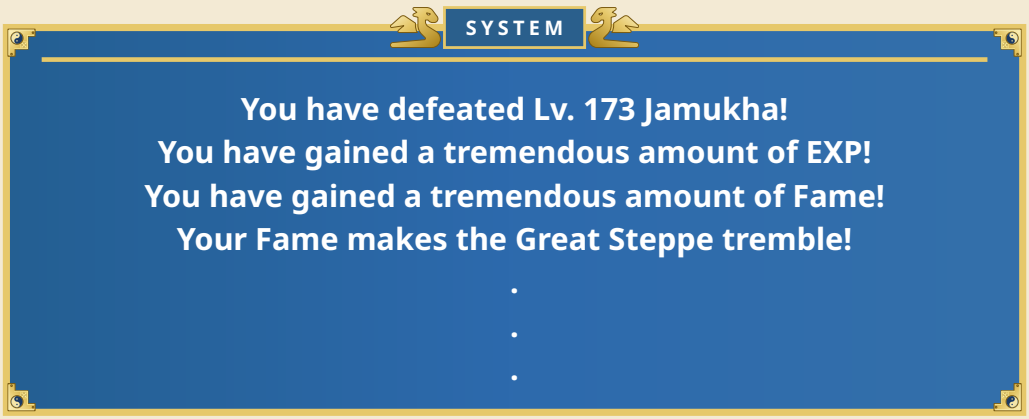
A quiet breath.

But despite unleashing strike after strike infused with tremendous internal energy, his lips, white a moment ago, were flushing red.

As if time were running backward.

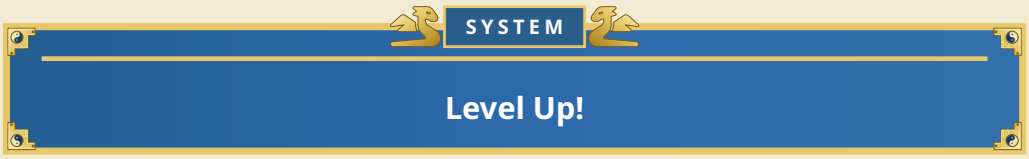
As if everything spent and worn away were returning to its original state.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Clear chimes rang in only one person's ears as translucent letters filled the air.

At the end of them were the words he'd been waiting for so long.



"Now I'm finally feeling alive."

Feeling that stroke of luck arrive just when he needed it, Jin Taekyung shivered.

Then he smiled past the shoulder of Jeok Cheongang, who stood firm as Mount Taishan, at the North Heaven Demon Lord staring back with wide eyes.

"There were two of you. Now you're alone."

Crack.

The North Heaven Demon Lord clenched his teeth hard enough to break them and drove Jeok Cheongang back with all his might.

Krrrunch! Bang!

Their tremendous clash flung them in opposite directions.

Rather than absorb the shock wave, the North Heaven Demon Lord used it to speed his retreat. Jeok Cheongang saw through his intent at once and shouted.

"You—!"

But the North Heaven Demon Lord didn't stop.

He cut through the wind and seemed to erase the space around him as he shot toward the narrow gorge's exit.

Shweeeee! Boom!

A casually thrown punch shattered the massive rocks filling the gorge. The North Heaven Demon Lord thrust his spear toward the people of Shanxi, still unable to advance past the obstacles blocking their way and the force of the collisions.

Rrrrrum.

Space warped. At its center, the spearhead gave off a blindingly ominous flash.

But that strike, carrying an unprecedented force, never swept across the people of Shanxi.

Shwack!

A gigantic arrow of light tore through the air and plunged toward the North Heaven Demon Lord.

Chapter 976

The instant the North Heaven Demon Lord sensed a chilling force plunge toward his back like a bolt of lightning, he spun around and swung his spear.

BOOOOM!

A tremendous collision.

Yet even as the unprecedented force carried on his spearhead swallowed the arrow of light, the North Heaven Demon Lord's face remained as hard as stone.

Because the attack aimed at him wasn't over.

Shwaaa!

The wind split apart.

A dozen or so streaks of light rushed at him through the pitch-black air. The North Heaven Demon Lord's eyes turned red.

"Bow Saint—!"

With an angry shout, the North Heaven Demon Lord realized he had no choice left and thrust out his spear.

Space warped along the path of its spearhead.

BOOOOM!

Krrrrk!

Space shuddered as if struck by an earthquake. A tremendous shock wave burst forth with a deafening roar, sweeping everything within a dozen or so *zhang*.[3551]

An enormous cloud of dust swallowed the narrow gorge in an instant. Through it came two gusts of wind, hotter than a midsummer afternoon and more suffocating than the desert sands far to the west.

Fwoosh.

The North Heaven Demon Lord felt that sudden blast of heat all too clearly.

And he saw them.

Two figures shooting toward him through the flash of light.

Two fists, born of the same root, wreathed in flames of different colors.

Gooooong.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Staring into the terrifying heat burning its way through space, the North Heaven Demon Lord thrust out his spear with all his strength.

Rrrrrum!

At its tip, a distant flash of light blazed.

[3551] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft); a dozen *zhang* is about 36 meters (120 ft).

It all began and ended in an instant.

Pangu.

As if the primordial giant said to have split the world with a single axe had drawn a deep breath, the air on every side pulled taut. Then it burst outward, sweeping everything away.

Rrrrrum!

What could they call it?

An explosion? A catastrophe?

Jin Wikyung and the people of Shanxi had no answer.

Crushed beneath an overwhelming force they had never experienced before—no, one they couldn't even have imagined—they could only watch as a vast wave of power swept toward them.

KABOOM! KAAAAABOOM!

The world turned upside down.

To keep from being flung away by the invisible shock wave, the people of Shanxi braced one another and drove their blades deep into the ground.

Their ears rang. Instinctive awe and terror gripped their bodies.

All of them, that was, except the few people responsible for the shock wave.

Shhk.

A spearhead cleaved through space.

Moving in a realm beyond sight and sound, Jin Taekyung and Jeok Cheongang dodged the Force shooting along its path and thrust out their fists.

Poom!

Air erupted with a blast of terrible heat.

The boom came late. By the time the flames that preceded it coiled through space, the North Heaven Demon Lord was already swooping down over their heads.

Shwaa!

His spearhead slashed down at an angle.

Just as Jin Taekyung twisted aside, the Force carried on the spearhead swelled and fell toward his shoulder.

Shhk.

I cut him.

The North Heaven Demon Lord was certain of it. He was right.

Except he had cut faintly red armor, not flesh and bone.

Pshk!

Blood spurted from the split in the Fire Dragon Armor, cut open by the Force.

That tiny amount—not even a handful—was all he had managed to draw. Master and disciple seized the opening.

Crack.

The instant Jin Taekyung clamped both hands around the spear shaft like hooks, the North Heaven Demon Lord understood on instinct.

Even with his physical abilities pushed to their limits by the Temporary Strength Pill, even with several *jiazi*[3552] of internal energy welling up without end, he could not withstand the strength of the young man before him.

What kind of monster is this…!

The higher you climbed, the farther you could see.

But even across the North Heaven Demon Lord's vast world, Jin Taekyung was a monster the likes of which he had never seen.

His accomplishments were unbelievable for his age. His physical abilities far surpassed even those called superhuman. And for some reason, ever since defeating Jamukha, his movements had grown faster and stronger, and his internal energy more powerful.

That alone made him a dangerous opponent. But what chilled the North Heaven Demon Lord's spine even more was the old monster fighting at the young one's side.

Whoom.

The moisture in the cold dawn air evaporated in an instant.

Jeok Cheongang charged in with a palm strike brimming with terrifying heat. Its glow lit the North Heaven Demon Lord's eyes red.

The Fire King…!

There was no other choice. No time even to look for one.

The North Heaven Demon Lord let go of the cherished spear he had carried for so many years and kicked off the ground.

Sss!

Burning pain seemed to seep into his very soul.

The flames surged after him as he retreated. Even a glancing touch melted his armor and scorched his skin.

And as the North Heaven Demon Lord endured that instant of pain and stumbled backward in a desperate retreat, the spearhead that had left him for a new master flashed toward him.

Shshshshk!

Dozens of spear images poured down, filling the air. The North Heaven Demon Lord drew on every sense, twisting and turning without pause, but the spearhead pursued him relentlessly. Blue-white flames surged from its tip.

[3552] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

Fwoosh! Shhk!

Hot.

Blood spurted through gaps in his armor where it had been cut and melted open. More blood than Jin Taekyung had shed, dark crimson blood that stained the North Heaven Demon Lord's vision as dizziness swept over him.

Then a quiet voice reached his ear.

"It's not over yet."

"…!"

"Grit your teeth."

Shhk, shhk, shhk!

It takes years to build something up. It takes only an instant to bring it down.

The spearhead swung again and again. The armor that had covered the North Heaven Demon Lord's entire body without a gap was all but useless.

Clank. Clatter!

Blood sprayed across shattered iron plates.

The North Heaven Demon Lord gritted his teeth against the searing pain.

His armor was not the only thing melting and breaking beneath the flames that struck him without pause.

Everything.

Everything he had accomplished as Murong Baek. Everything he had hoped to accomplish as the North Heaven Demon Lord. His past and future were turning to ash and scattering bit by bit.

Why!

He screamed inwardly, gathered the immense power he had left into his fist, and hurled it outward.

BOOM!

Space shook with a roar like the heavens splitting open.

Yet the strike, powerful enough to bring down a mountain, touched nothing. It only tore through empty air.

"Long ago, whenever I saw you, I had the same thought."

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

The old monster of Mount Jiuhua, who had lived for more than a hundred years, stepped toward the North Heaven Demon Lord.

Whoosh.

Jeok vanished as if he had evaporated. At the same instant, tremendous heat scorched the North Heaven Demon Lord's side.

Fwoosh.

Blinding light-flames swallowed the darkness. The North Heaven Demon Lord instinctively looked up, his eyes turning white with their light.

“You really do have the kind of eyes no one can trust.”

In that instant, the North Heaven Demon Lord saw it.

A savage blaze at odds with Jeok Cheongang’s calm voice.

A dazzling wave of fire, neither red nor blue.

BOOOOM!

The roar followed the movement a moment later, shaking everything around them.

Unable to withstand the force, the North Heaven Demon Lord crashed deep into the cliff wall and swallowed the blood surging up his throat.

Not yet. Not yet.

It wasn’t over. He couldn’t fall.

His vision blurring, he pushed against the cliff wall cradling his body and tried to rise.

Tried to.

Until a flash of light flickered through the dust cloud rising pale beyond the countless rock fragments raining down from the collision.

Thud! Krrrk!

The spearhead, wreathed in blue-white flame and terrible heat, pierced his shoulder. It smashed through bone and flesh and lodged deep in the cliff.

“…!”

His entire body quivered with indescribable pain.

But the North Heaven Demon Lord refused to give up. Though pain turned his vision white, he struggled with all his strength.

“GRAAAAAH!”

Crack! Fwoosh!

At last, the spearhead came free—or rather, his body did.

Rather than pull the spear from the cliff, the North Heaven Demon Lord gritted his teeth and tore his shoulder off the blade. Then he kicked off the ground and shot upward.

He burst through the churning dust cloud, bounding off the cliff face and the very air.

Away from the two monsters who had driven him to the brink of death.

Toward the only path of escape left to him.

Shweee!

The pain and injuries should have felled him long ago. His internal energy should have dwindled to a mere handful. But the Temporary Strength Pill made him forget both.

The North Heaven Demon Lord pushed onward with every ounce of strength he had.

Thinking of the prey who would be frozen in disbelief beyond the thick dust cloud settling all around.

The only lifeline that could save him.

Jin Wikyung.

The Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and the Alliance Leader from Shanxi Province who had led its forces in today's battle.

And someone's precious flesh and blood.

If I capture him, I have a way out.

He had spent his life first as heir, then as Family Head of the Murong Family, one of the Five Great Families.

Black on the inside, white on the outside.

How many years had he lived among the orthodox faction, hiding the teeth of a beast?

The North Heaven Demon Lord knew those who called themselves orthodox better than anyone: their nature, their habits, the way they thought.

He knew, too, that the young upstart of the Jin Family of Taiyuan who had cornered him alongside the Fire King was bound more tightly than anyone by the word *righteousness*.

That's why. It's the greatest reason you can't defeat me—or us.

They had lost a battle in which both sides had given everything, and the grand plan they had been certain would succeed had come to nothing.

But that didn't mean the end.

If he survived, another chance would come.

And the North Heaven Demon Lord would return.

In the not-too-distant future, before the sting of his defeat and his enemies' cheers had faded, he would once more unfurl the Murong Family's banner and stride across the land.

Beneath a dark sky, with his hidden fangs bared to the fullest.

I will return. Even if I have to stake everything on it.

Remembering the defeat and humiliation he had suffered today, the North Heaven Demon Lord renewed his resolve.

He failed to notice that pain and hope had numbed his reason into making a foolish judgment.

He couldn't even properly wonder why Jeok Cheongang and Jin Taekyung weren't chasing him, even in this situation.

At last, beyond the dispersing dust, he saw Jin Wikyung—the man he had been so desperate to find.

And someone else standing tall before him, in front of Jin Wikyung, who had led everyone from the front since the beginning.

“Bow… Saint.”

Splash.

A low groan escaped the North Heaven Demon Lord’s lips.

Just as his steps—which had seemed as if they would go on forever—stopped in a pool of blood, he stared at the Bow Saint with hollow eyes. Then someone’s voice drifted into his ears.

“Poppy. Where did you go, Poppy?”

An anxious voice rang through the dust cloud.

Moments later, Jin Taekyung suddenly emerged from within it and stared wide-eyed at the North Heaven Demon Lord.

“Oh my god, Poppy! What are you doing here?”

“…!”

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s eyelids twitched.

Chapter 977

Shame was only one of the many emotions every human being felt, but its weight varied enormously from person to person.

For a slave scorned from the moment they were in their mother's womb, shame might be no different from fate. For the noble and the wealthy, it could tear at the heart more cruelly and sharply than any blade.

And the North Heaven Demon Lord was very much the latter.

"Our Poppy! I was wondering where you'd run off to in such a panic. There you are."

A face and voice full of concern.

And a smile whose lopsidedly raised corners made that concern look all the more absurd.

"I was so worried. I thought I might've lost you for good."

With every mocking word Jin Taekyung spoke, the North Heaven Demon Lord's eyelids twitched.

As if walking into an obvious trap of his own accord weren't bad enough, now he was being treated like a dog that had run away from home.

The shame and despair gripping him were unlike anything he had ever felt before.

"How dare a nobody like you—"

"Shut up."

Jeok Cheongang appeared beyond the thinning cloud of dust, cutting the North Heaven Demon Lord off. His gaze had gone cold and deep.

"Who do you think you are, running your mouth like that? You're a nobody."

The North Heaven Demon Lord gritted his teeth.

Why was this happening?

In his eyes, Jeok Cheongang had grown as imposing and brilliant as he had been long ago, during the Great Faction War.

The sight brought back the man he had once been, shrinking without realizing it before the giant known as the Fire King.

Step.

Footsteps rang unusually clear in his ears.

But Jeok Cheongang stopped on his way toward him and let out a short laugh.

"I've walked a good ten paces, yet I'm no closer. I feel like I've been bewitched. Don't you?"

At his Master's question, Jin Taekyung frowned as if puzzled.

"Come on, that can't be right. Maybe you're imagining it?"

"Imagining it?"

“That makes no sense. It’s not like you’re walking in place. Why wouldn’t you be any closer?”

Scratching his chin, Jin Taekyung went on with a perfectly straight face. He glanced at the North Heaven Demon Lord’s stiff expression.

“Unless some coward got scared and started backing away.”

“…!”

“Oh, wait. Is that it? Seriously?”

Crack.

Skin split, and blood flowed.

The North Heaven Demon Lord had clenched his teeth hard enough to split his lips. He looked down at the legs that had carried him backward on instinct.

Or perhaps he’d looked away because he couldn’t bear to face the mockery on that bloodied brat’s face.

If he didn’t at least look away, he felt he might lose the last thread of reason he had left.

“Wow, it really was true. A minute ago, you took a pill and started acting all high and mighty, throwing a goddamn fit.”

Jin Taekyung strode closer with another taunt.

But this time, the North Heaven Demon Lord didn’t retreat.

No—he couldn’t.

Soft step.

Unlike the master and Disciple blocking his path, the footsteps behind him were light as feathers.

He half-turned. A woman approached like a gentle breeze.

The Bow Saint.

Caught between them. Surrounded on all sides.

Neither phrase came close to describing his situation.

Three Supreme Peak masters.

One was a member of the Three Saints, known throughout the world. Another was an old sovereign who stood shoulder to shoulder with her. And the last was a young Divine Dragon, soaring toward the heavens with that sovereign’s teachings as his dragon pearl.

This can’t be happening. It can’t.

The words slipped out alone from a hollow corner of his heart.

Then, at some point, the trembling in the North Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes subsided. His gaze settled.

“Even if you defeat me here today, nothing will change.”

Jin Taekyung shot back without hesitation.

“Do you people go around memorizing speeches or something? Is there a punishment if you get even one word wrong? Your internal energy gets confiscated for a week?”

“Say whatever you want. It makes no difference. That is the only truth.”

“We’ve done a pretty good job stopping you so far, though. Today included.”

At Jin Taekyung’s reply, the North Heaven Demon Lord let out a short laugh despite himself.

“If that’s what you believe, then so be it. There’s nothing wrong with holding on to hope.”

“What?”

“Finding myself in this situation made me wonder. Why did the Western Heaven Demon Lord, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord fail? How did a plan they’d spent so long preparing fall apart in an instant?”

Jin Taekyung’s face hardened at the unexpected words. So did everyone else’s.

“What are you trying to say?”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice was cold. He looked ready to burn the man alive on the spot, but the North Heaven Demon Lord answered calmly.

“I don’t know. I’m not sure what I’m trying to say.”

“You bastard—!”

“Don’t rush, Fire King. Even if you don’t hurry me, we don’t have much time left.”

With his mind emptied, his voice was calm as well. The North Heaven Demon Lord looked inward, contemplating the energy that remained in his body, and continued.

“Half a year at most. That’s all.”

The war had already begun.

It had begun the day the absolute ruler in the darkness awoke from a long slumber.

No—long before that.

“Power beyond anything the hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path possessed. Unbelievable powers. ‘A new heaven’ refers to that person.”

Everyone there knew whom the North Heaven Demon Lord meant.

“The Lord of Heaven…”

The Bow Saint murmured to herself, then lifted her clear eyes to look at the North Heaven Demon Lord.

“Was that why you abandoned the comrades who shared life and death with you, and betrayed the world?”

“Comrades? Did you just call them comrades?”

The North Heaven Demon Lord suddenly burst into a hearty laugh.

Comrades. People who walked the same path.

The meaning held in those two words—their utterly worthless value and the past they called to mind—made him laugh in spite of himself.

“It seems you lived in a different world from me. Well, what could you possibly know, when you shut yourselves away in remote mountain valleys without roots, turning your backs on the world?”

His bloodshot eyes moved over Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint in turn.

Neither of them had been known by name before the Great Faction War. They had been eccentric, reclusive masters.

But the North Heaven Demon Lord—Murong Baek—was different.

As a direct descendant of the Murong Family, one of the Five Great Families, he had seen the world. He had to wage covert battles against others who shared the same orthodox fold.

“Everyone smiled and spoke of righteousness while hiding unseen blades in their sleeves. Is that what you call comrades? Is this the orthodox faction?”

Even the stars looking down on the world would one day lose their light and fade.

Everything grew old and declined.

The world of martial artists was no different.

As time passed, the martial world had disappeared. All that remained was a cold Murim.

Chivalry had lost more and more of its worth, while the orthodox faction—including the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families—poured its strength into struggles for power.

Taking in countless lay disciples to expand the sects under their control had become commonplace.

Some even committed the taboo of bringing the unorthodox faction into their fold. Others caused numerous casualties in clashes waged in secret.

Expansion ended in an explosion.

The power they had built up over so many years was eating away at the orthodox faction in the form of conflict.

And the northern lands, far from the Central Plains, were no exception.

If anything, things were harsher there.

At least for the Murong Family.

“You can’t claim you don’t know what roots I—or rather, the Murong Family—come from.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord looked down at the pool of blood beneath his feet.

He had the handsome features of a man who had spent his life as the Family Head of a prestigious great family, and the authority and strength to match.

Yet even after all the years the Murong Family had been rooted in Liaoning Province, the faint traces of his foreign ancestry still flowed through his veins.

Enough to bring to mind, for a moment, the face of Jamukha lying dead.

“Nomad?”

At Jin Taekyung’s murmured question, the North Heaven Demon Lord’s fist clenched on instinct, his knuckles turning white.

He had heard that word countless times.

The pointing fingers and voices that had followed him from out of sight were still there in his eyes and ears.

Nomad. Invader. Outsider.

And barbarian.

Long ago, the northeastern people called the Murong Xianbei had occupied the edge of the continent and founded a nation.

It was an age of chaos.

Five foreign peoples and sixteen small kingdoms[3553] stood divided across the land.

But the divided land eventually found stability, and the invaders who had used the turmoil to charge across the continent with lances and composite bows were either driven beyond the Great Wall or absorbed.

The Murong Xianbei were among those absorbed.

They remained in Liaoning Province and laid new foundations, establishing a great family.

The Murong Family was born.

A family of invaders descended from barbarian blood.

Their peerless martial arts and superb horsemanship had made them a towering force in Murim. Yet the other towering forces—the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families—had looked down on them and treated them with contempt, though never openly.

“Sometimes I wondered: if the Great Faction War had never happened, would the Murong Family have survived to this day?”

Expansion ended in an explosion, but the aftermath of an explosion beyond anyone’s imagination could leave reconciliation and peace behind.

The arrival of the Demonic Cult as an outside enemy changed everything.

To survive, everyone had to join forces and fight together. The Murim Alliance, formed around the Martial God, united the feuding orthodox faction.

But Murong Baek—and the Murong Family—hadn’t forgotten.

They remembered it all clearly.

[3553] The Five Barbarians and Sixteen Kingdoms refers to a period of upheaval in northern China during the fourth and fifth centuries CE, when non-Han peoples founded competing states.

“There is no more chivalry. No more benevolence or righteousness. In the end, the only ones who survive through the years are the strong.”

The strong prey on the weak.

That was the only truth of the world the North Heaven Demon Lord had learned.

The only value and purpose in a Murim built on violence.

And so Murong Baek became the North Heaven Demon Lord.

“That was why. Nothing else.”

Rumble. Rumble.

A powerful tremor spread across the ground.

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s eyes were now so red that “bloodshot” no longer described them. His blood-red gaze swept over everyone in the gorge as he roared.

“Who dares! What hypocrite has the right to condemn me!”

BOOOOM!

The internal energy carried in his aged shout burst outward as a mighty sonic wave.

The aura was truly terrifying.

Blood flowed from the ears of the people of Shanxi, frozen like statues. Several who had been shaken to their cores by the roar alone coughed up blood and dropped to their knees.

Vrrrrm.

Terrible power churned around one man.

Though gravely wounded, he radiated a vast wave of qi that seemed to squeeze the air on every side. Jeok Cheongang realized the North Heaven Demon Lord had already crossed the point of no return.

Innate qi.

Just like the heads of Dark Heaven who had gone to the afterlife before him, the North Heaven Demon Lord was burning up everything he had been given in that moment.

Even knowing death waited at the end.

“If I tell you to back off, will you?”

At Jeok Cheongang’s quiet question, his Disciple reached out without a word.

Whoosh—tap.

A spear shaft shot toward Jin Taekyung from behind like an arrow, and he caught it firmly. Blue-white flames surged up and wound around the almost transparent spearhead. That was answer enough.

“I’ve had to listen to this bullshit for so long my whole body aches.”

“You’re too young to ache all over.”

Jeok Cheongang gave a short laugh, and Jin Taekyung laughed with him.

“I’ll go on ahead. You two can take your time catching up.”

At the same moment, dirt and rock crumbled beneath Jin Taekyung's toes.

Crack—BOOM!

The ground split like a spiderweb, and a streak of flame shot forward.

The two old monsters blurred, following the Divine Dragon as he charged ahead with greater speed and force than ever.

Flash.

As the distance vanished between them, a blood-red glow surged upward.

Chapter 978

Every now and then, I catch myself realizing how much I've changed.

In this miserable fight, where every moment demands that I risk my life, I keep moving forward—and feel a thrill I can't explain.

"Jin Taekyung!"

A shout like a lion's roar lashed at my ears.

Beyond the wind whipping around me, I brought White Flame down on the blood-red light bursting from the North Heaven Demon Lord's fingertips.

Shhk!

The enormous Palm Force split in two along the path of my spearhead.

Leaving behind the tremendous impact and explosion as the deflected Palm Force shook the cliffs on either side, I planted my foot on the ground once more.

Tap.

The flames that should have burst forth from Flamefire Path were nowhere to be seen.

My feet, guided by the Slaughter Saint's teachings, felt lighter than ever. I shot forward like a flash of light.

Like the beam that had suddenly come streaking from far across the gorge.

Shwaaa!

Compressed air tore apart. At the arrow of light that had outrun even sound, the North Heaven Demon Lord swung a fist seething with rage and internal energy.

BOOOOM!

Contact. Then an explosion.

Within the swelling flash, I saw the beam the Bow Saint had shot vanish into the dark red glow.

I seized the opening. By the time the North Heaven Demon Lord's eyes caught my reflection, I was right in front of him.

I can see it.

The world slowed in an instant.

Everything around me was sharp and vivid.

His lips moving slowly, as though he were trying to say something.

His eyes, so red there wasn't a trace of white left in them.

And the condensed Palm Force blocking the spearhead I had thrust forward with all my might.

Krrrk!

Two different Forces collided. Blue-white flames and dark red shadows met in midair, mingling as they sent out a violent wave of force.

“Just… this much.”

His words came in broken fragments.

The North Heaven Demon Lord glared at me, gripping my spearhead in one hand. Streams of blazing red seemed to pour from his eyes.

“Did you think you could defeat me—Murong Baek—with this?”

Zzzzzzt!

An unprecedented energy flared up like a wildfire, pressing down on the flames carried by my spearhead. The power the North Heaven Demon Lord had gained by burning even his own life came at a steep and tremendous price: a death already set in stone.

Even with all my fatigue and injuries completely healed after I took down Jamukha, victory seemed impossible.

But…

Yeah. This is about what I expected.

I smiled.

The strength I sensed from the North Heaven Demon Lord was within the range I’d expected.

And the energy rushing in from behind me, fast as a flash of light, was immense enough to rival his.

Now.

There was no shouted warning. No Sound Transmission.

But I knew. So did he.

Even without seeing each other, we knew each other too well.

So, without the slightest fear or hesitation, we moved as the thought flashed through our minds.

Slip.

The instant I let go of the spear shaft and turned halfway around—

A streak of flame, hidden behind my body—a frame massive enough to be called a giant—filled the space I’d left and exploded.

Gooooong.

Like the breath of a fire dragon from legend, pure white hellfire blazed across the darkness.

It burned away the dew in the dawn air, vaporizing it as it rushed toward the North Heaven Demon Lord.

Fire. King.

His lips moved ever so slightly, forming a soundless cry. His eyes, heated by the scorching air, wavered, losing their focus.

Confusion and fear he couldn’t hide.

Those emotions, revealed on instinct, meant the North Heaven Demon Lord had sensed someone else—not me or Jeok Cheongang.

Shwaaa!

Behind him, two gently curved blades traced beautiful arcs.

The strike was utterly unlike the furious flames bearing down on him from the front, yet the energy it carried was no less deadly.

"…!"

In the slowed world, the North Heaven Demon Lord's eyes flew wide.

Jeok Cheongang's Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist came from the front. From behind, the Bow Saint's twin blades, transformed into curved swords, came down on him.

Two Supreme Peak masters unleashed a terrifying combined attack. With neither time nor room to dodge, he had no choice left.

BOOM! KAAAAAABOOM!

In an instant, all the darkness hanging over the gorge lifted.

A blood-red glow burst out, wrapping around the North Heaven Demon Lord's entire body.

Krrrrrk!

The world shook. A relentless wave of force swept in every direction, and the ground crumbled beneath the three combatants' feet.

Crack! Krrrk!

The ground split like a spiderweb, unable to withstand the tremendous pressure.

As I had done at the last moment, the North Heaven Demon Lord twisted his body and changed direction. His whole frame shuddered violently like a tree caught in a typhoon.

His face twisted like a Fiend's as he caught Jeok Cheongang's fist in one hand and both of the Bow Saint's curved blades in the other.

No. He was already a Fiend. Had been for a long time.

No matter how many years a monster spent wearing a human face, its nature didn't disappear.

The North Heaven Demon Lord—Murong Baek—had crossed a river from which there was no return.

Like so many other monsters who had pursued the Demonic Path for their own reasons, heading off somewhere.

Crack—splatter!

Blood gushed from the flesh and joints of bone, slowly being cut and crushed.

The North Heaven Demon Lord convulsed in pain beyond anything he had imagined.

Both hands, holding off the Fire King and the Bow Saint, were losing their shape even now.

Yet one thing would remain unchanged to the end: those eyes filled with bitter hatred.

“Why? Why…?”

I could feel all the pain and hatred in the North Heaven Demon Lord’s voice as he ground the words out through teeth clenched hard enough to draw blood.

I could feel the sliver of fear he couldn’t quite hide as I slowly approached, too.

“I… won’t… die.”

The North Heaven Demon Lord’s words broke apart between gasping breaths. Jeok Cheongang answered, his expression calm.

“Everyone dies. People and monsters alike.”

The blood-red light that seemed about to devour the whole world and the force that had been pressing down on everything around us were nowhere to be seen now.

Even if some remained, they were fading like a lamp before the wind.

Krrrk.

The pressure was more than one hand could withstand.

Before the white hellfire Jeok Cheongang drew forth with all his strength, alongside his quiet reply, the North Heaven Demon Lord finally dropped to one knee.

BOOM!

The ground caved in beneath him. The Bow Saint’s voice reached the North Heaven Demon Lord as he stared with eyes bulging wide.

“We’re born human, and we make our choices by our own judgment. There is no right answer. But… this is the consequence of your choice.”

What life has a right answer?

Life isn’t multiple choice. It isn’t a test graded on short answers or essays, either.

Whatever life a person has lived, looking back, there will always be at least one thing they regret. That is what human life is.

But both the judgment and the consequences are your own. That’s all.

“Murong Baek, the Divine Spear of the Imugi. No—the North Heaven Demon Lord. It’s time to accept the consequence of your choice.”

There’s a reason and a history behind every martial artist’s sobriquet.

When I heard that unfamiliar one from the Bow Saint’s lips, I felt as though I’d caught a glimpse of the life Murong Baek had lived.

The imugi.

An imugi that never became a dragon.

And at the same time, an imugi that had wanted to become a dragon more than anyone.

Maybe that was why.

Why he had struggled so desperately to obtain the dragon pearl.

Why he had searched for every excuse and justification to remain beneath Dark Heaven's shadow, hoping to become a dragon soaring freely through the azure heaven.

But knowing something and understanding it are different.

Even if every story he'd told us was true, I would never understand Murong Baek, the North Heaven Demon Lord.

No. I would refuse to understand him.

The day I understood him would be the day I became a monster, too, on the far side of that deep, dark river.

"Before you go, know this."

With a quiet voice, I reached out.

The pure white spear shaft the North Heaven Demon Lord had been forced to let go of to face Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint flew into my grip as though drawn there.

"Not everyone in the world makes the same choice you did."

The weak are cast aside, and the strong survive.

That's how this world has always been—always, without fail.

The law of the jungle existed not just in Murim, but in the modern world, too. And it would continue to exist, with means other than spears and swords.

But if everyone made the same choice as the North Heaven Demon Lord out of fear of being cast aside, the world would already have become a hellscape.

A place without even the barest sense of decency or benevolence.

A terrible world that went on endlessly for one purpose alone: to devour others or be devoured.

But not everyone is like the North Heaven Demon Lord. That's why I still think this world is worth living in.

And I believe, too—

Among all those countless people scattered like stars across the night sky, whoever gave such inexplicable power to an unremarkable F-rank Hunter must feel the same way.

"Now, go."

I didn't wait for an answer.

I simply thrust my spearhead, wreathed in blue-white flames, into him—quietly and without hesitation.

Toward the North Heaven Demon Lord, who still refused to give up, struggling as he burned through every bit of life left in his body.

Toward the chest of a monster who had lived not simply to protect what was precious to him, but to seize what belonged to others and make himself greater.

Thud.

The blazing flames pierced flesh and bone.

As if someone had lit a candle, the being in the darkness suddenly opened its eyes.

How long had it been asleep?

How much time had passed in that abyssal dream where everything was tangled together?

It couldn’t know.

The question was familiar, and the conclusion was always the same.

It had always been that way for the being in the darkness.

Whenever it woke, the world had changed. It had once slept for decades, after all.

But as the years passed and the intervals between its awakenings grew shorter, it had begun to realize something.

The day it had thought it would never reach had, at some point, drawn right up to its doorstep.

Fwoooosh.

A cool wind swept through the area. In moments, it became a raging gale.

It extinguished the torches that faintly lit the thick darkness and shook the ground and roof.

That sudden upheaval, like great waves rising on a tranquil lake, was proof that the being in the darkness had realized why it had opened its eyes.

North Heaven.

The fourth heaven had fallen. Another faithful servant was gone.

The news would soon shock all beneath the heavens.

But alone in the darkness, the being smiled.

Chapter 979

At some point, everyone realized.

“Waaaaah!”

A tremendous roar shook heaven and earth as it rolled over the narrow gorge called Eight Spring Gorge.

The fighters locked in fierce battle across the vast basin all turned their heads at once.

Their lips were cracked like drought-stricken fields. Their hands and feet trembled with exhaustion and fear of death.

After hours of fighting, they were covered in blood from head to toe. They stared desperately toward the gorge’s entrance, praying that the roar drawing closer—and the countless footsteps pounding the earth—belonged to their allies.

Then, beyond the thinning darkness, a streak of light flashed.

Shwaaaaa! BOOM!

In an instant, a deafening crash mingled with screams.

But Iron Blood Saber Peng Cheolyeong, Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family, recognized the light and laughed at the top of his lungs.

“Ha! Hahahaha!”

Crack!

With that booming laugh, he swung his great saber and swept through a dozen nomads in a single stroke.

Beneath the fountain of blood soaring into the air, the fewer than one thousand remaining warriors of Hebei pressed forward behind their Family Head.

Just moments ago, their bodies and weapons had felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton. Now, they felt impossibly light.

As they advanced, laughing like madmen, a thick mist of blood rose in their wake.

Shhk! Shhk-shhk!

“Aaargh!”

“Guh!”

Screams erupted everywhere. Neither the Murong Family’s martial artists, trained in their family’s secret arts, nor the nomads who had once swept across the land with lance and bow could stop the Hebei Peng Family.

No—more precisely, they had frozen at the unbelievable sight before them.

Rumble!

The ground shuddered.

As dawn approached and the darkness faded, thousands of figures poured from the narrow gorge’s entrance. A blood-soaked banner rose high above them.

The Great Jin Family of Taiyuan.

“…!”

“…!”

It could mean only one thing.

Eyes fixed on the characters embroidered on the banner trembled.

Some with shock and despair. Others with hope and joy.

But there were those who belonged to neither side.

“Enough! What are you all thinking?”

The Murong Family’s Head Elder, Murong Wijin, who had been directing the battlefield in Murong Baek’s place, shouted with internal energy behind his voice.

His followers flinched beneath his venomous glare.

“Don’t fall for their petty tricks! This is—this is just…”

Murong Wijin clenched his teeth, unable to finish.

What else could he say?

Anyone who wasn’t a fool could see what was happening.

Reality was chillingly cold.

They had lost. Their enemies had won.

And the ones who had returned to finish it all were neither Jamukha nor Murong Baek. They were the people of Shanxi.

Holding the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s banner so high it seemed to pierce the sky, they approached in tight formation. There was certainty in every step.

Certainty of victory.

Perhaps certainty in the four people leading them.

“Hold on. I’ve seen that guy’s face somewhere.”

His hair had grown into prickly stubble, like a lazy monk’s, and was so red it seemed to be on fire.

Facing the old monster who looked decades younger than he ought to, Murong Wijin trembled.

“F-Fire King…!”

“Oh, now I vaguely remember. Murong… whatever. Right?”

Jeok Cheongang nodded as if he’d finally figured it out. The woman beside him sighed.

“Murong Wijin. Not ‘whatever’—Wijin. And if he’s wearing the Murong Family’s uniform, obviously his surname is Murong.”

“Wijin? Who’s that?”

“That’s understandable. During the Great Faction War, he wasn’t even thirty. He was a child.”

Though Murong Wijin was nearing eighty, he couldn’t say a word.

In front of two monsters like the Fire King and the Bow Saint, he was still no more than a hot-blooded novice in Murim.

In age and in martial arts.

And there was someone else here who didn't give a damn about either.

"Hey, what's your name again? Murong… thingy."

Murong Wijin's face stiffened at being renamed by both Master and Disciple. Then Jin Taekyung stepped forward and swung his spear.

Whoosh!

The spear's fierce whistle crossed dozens of yards. The round shape impaled on its tip fell precisely at Murong Wijin's feet.

Thump.

When Murong Wijin saw what touched the tips of his shoes—an object that was, in fact, a person's head—a groan escaped him before he could stop it.

"…Family Head."

Once spoken, words couldn't be taken back.

Murong Wijin belatedly realized his mistake and clamped his mouth shut, but the damage was done.

"You… You dare…"

"What? Not enough? Want another?"

Jin Taekyung swung his spear again, and another head sailed through the air.

This time, the nomads bit their lips as they recognized the face of Jamukha, the steppe's greatest warrior and Great Chieftain.

"If you need more, say so. No, wait. I take that back."

Jin Taekyung shook his head and started walking.

Thud.

His footsteps rang out with unusual weight and clarity.

His reddish, smoldering eyes swept across the vast basin.

"There are too many to bring here one by one. Better to make them on the spot. Fresh from the source."

"…!"

"…!"

The Murong Family and the nomads—every one of them—instinctively stepped back.

Though they still had nearly ten thousand troops, an overwhelming aura and killing intent flowed from Jin Taekyung. No one dared stand against him.

And in that suffocating silence, another voice rang out.

"If you lay down your weapons and surrender now, your lives will be spared."

One man had been overshadowed by the three Supreme Peak masters.

He had neither several jiazi[3554] of internal energy nor the godlike power to stand shoulder to shoulder with them. Yet he carried an inexplicable authority.

Perhaps it was an authority only someone who had raised a declining family and become the Alliance Leader of Shanxi Province could possess.

“You have my word. On my name, and on the authority of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

Jin Wikyung continued calmly.

His gaze rested on a young chieftain who looked particularly haggard.

“Choose, Temur.”

“…!”

“I know you. And I know you didn’t come here of your own will.”

Temur clenched his teeth.

“I’ve… come too far.”

His brother, with whom he’d shared years of hardship, was dead. And Temur had submitted.

He meant what he said. He had come too far to return to the steppe, to his homeland.

But Jin Wikyung shook his head.

“It’s not too late. Not yet.”

“…Why? Why are you offering me this?”

“Because too much blood has already been spilled. If I can prevent any more deaths, I’ll do whatever it takes.”

Despite his composed voice, a tear ran down Jin Wikyung’s cheek.

“That’s all.”

Seeing Jin Wikyung weep, feeling the sincerity in his words, Temur could hardly breathe.

He thought of the path he had chosen, so different from Jin Wikyung’s. Of all the tribespeople who had died here today because he had submitted to save his own life.

“What… do you want me to do?”

“You bastard!”

At Murong Wijin’s furious shout, the Murong Family’s martial artists moved. But a dense forest of lances had already closed in around them.

Before the army of ten thousand, now split in two in the blink of an eye, Jin Wikyung spoke.

“Surrender and submit to us. Completely.”

“…!”

[3554] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

"Too much? Then refuse. You can join forces with the Murong Family right now if you wish. But—"

Jin Wikyung's voice hardened, then burst into a mighty shout.

"We will fight. We will cross the Great Wall and trample the steppe. Whatever the cost, we will drive you out of there!"

At that moment, a chill ran down Temur's spine.

The thousands of surviving nomads felt it, too.

They all heard and felt Jin Wikyung's resolve to repay this grudge, even if it took hundreds of years and cost countless lives.

They heard the sincerity in his tightly restrained voice, seeping through clenched teeth.

And then, Temur had no choice but to decide.

"…Temur of the Golden Clan."

Temur—the only chieftain who could fill Jamukha's place—bowed his head.

To the Han Chinese beyond the Great Wall.

To the Alliance Leader of Shanxi and the Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

"I offer my greetings, my lord."

In that instant, time on the battlefield—which had stood still—began to flow again.

Shhk-shhk-shhk!

The forest of lances swallowed the Murong Family. Behind it, thousands of people of Shanxi charged beneath the Jin Family of Taiyuan's fluttering banner.

The blood-soaked night of the Double Ninth Festival[3555] finally woke to the dawn.

In the hazy space between dream and reality, the young man had forgotten even his own existence. He was trapped in the layers of memory piled up in his mind.

Shwaack!

The child could have been no more than four or five.

With a seriousness that didn't suit his age, he swung a wooden sword as tall as he was. Each stroke cut the air with a sharp hiss.

No one knew when he'd begun or how many times he'd swung it. His little body was already soaked with sweat.

People standing at one side of the training ground watched in amazement, repeatedly letting out cries of admiration.

"Incredible. He's held a sword for only six months, and he can already deliver a strike like that."

[3555]The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

“Good heavens. What a martial talent.”

“Look at that speed and trajectory. Fast and precise. It’s hard to believe he’s so young.”

“What’s truly remarkable is that he knows how to work hard. Think about it. Have any of you ever seen a child like him?”

“Never. Even the Head Elder, who was called Shanxi Province’s greatest prodigy in his youth, wasn’t like this. Though the Central Plains did have so many outstanding talents.”

“The Lesser Family Head showed such promise as a child, but then one day he became more interested in books than martial arts.”

“A shame. If he’d kept training with the sword, he’d have reached at least the Supreme First Rate realm by now.”

“What can you do? It’s in the past. The Family Head has always been unpredictable. I suppose the son inherited it from him.”

Family Head.

At the two words someone let slip, everyone clicked their tongues.

They exchanged strange glances and fell silent, but only for a moment.

Watching the child practice his sword with flawless form, stroke after stroke, they resumed their conversation as if nothing had happened.

“In any case, I don’t know much about the great sects of the Central Plains, but I doubt they have many talents like him. No, they must be quite rare.”

“He’s a great blessing to our family. Though it troubles me how gloomy he’s become for a child his age since his mother died in childbirth…”

“Mm.”

The words trailed off, and everyone’s face darkened.

“It’s tragic, but there’s nothing to be done.”

“What can we do? It’s the fate ordained by Heaven.”

“Fate? What fate?”

At the voice from somewhere nearby, the murmured conversation stopped short.

The next moment, as if by agreement, everyone fell silent and looked urgently in the same direction.

So did the young man, who had been watching it all from a spot neither near nor far.

“F-Family Head!”

Hearing someone blurt out the cry in a rush, the young man—who had just turned his head—furrowed his brow.

Perhaps it was the sunset glow spreading from the west. He couldn’t make out the face of the man slowly approaching.

Only a voice reached him, strangely familiar and faintly wistful.

“Well, judging by your reactions, I must be an unwelcome guest.”

He was a man of ordinary build.

Nothing more to add, nothing to take away.

Yet even without seeing his face, the young man could sense something distinctive about him as he scratched the back of his head.

The others facing the man, of course, couldn’t hide their confusion.

“N-No, of course not.”

“Don’t give me that. Do I look so oblivious?”

Beneath the face hidden by the sunset, his faintly visible lips curved into a smile.

He looked over the people silently watching him, then spoke again.

“I was passing by and stopped in for a moment. Don’t mind me. It seems you were watching my second son train.”

“We could hardly claim to be teaching him. The Second Young Master is so gifted that we wouldn’t dare try to correct him.”

“Of course he is. Whose son do you think he is?”

The man puffed out his chest, plainly proud. But the young man saw the smile at his lips falter and turn bitter.

Nor were the people who’d been restless ever since the man appeared any different.

“We’re sorry, Family Head.”

“We spoke out of turn. Please punish us.”

Their voices and expressions were heavy.

As they lowered their heads, the young man clicked his tongue softly without realizing it.

He didn’t know who he was or where he was, but he could infer what was happening from what he’d heard and seen.

Speaking of Heaven’s fate in front of a Family Head who had recently lost his wife…

Whatever they had intended, they deserved punishment.

Just as a nation needed strict laws to stand firm, a family had rules that must be observed.

But the man called Family Head answered in a way the young man hadn’t expected at all.

“Punishment? What are you talking about all of a sudden?”

“Pardon?”

“I told you, I just stopped by on my way past. Oh, was that talk about fate related to me? I wondered what profound conversation you were having.”

“W-Well, that is…”

“Now I’m starting to get the picture. I know how this goes. You were bad-mouthing the Family Head who lazes around all day again, weren’t you?”

“F-Family Head, that’s not…”

“Enough. You people, honestly. I may be the Family Head, but you can’t just gossip about me behind my back.”

The man folded his arms. The others, now on tenterhooks, glanced at one another.

Should they tell the truth, or let it go?

As they agonized, their mouths going dry, the man let out a deep sigh.

“Whew. You’ve confessed this much, so there’s no choice. As Family Head, I can’t just pretend I didn’t hear it. I’ll punish you now.”

Around him, people let out breaths they’d been holding.

Better to take the punishment than keep carrying the weight of guilt. Their faces relaxed as the man continued.

“Confined to your quarters. For half a day.”

“F-Family Head…”

“You’ve looked tired lately. Stay in your quarters for half a day, then get back to work. Oh, and make sure you give our eldest plenty of help.”

That was all.

The man waved away the retainers who tried to say something, dismissing them. Then he looked toward the child, who kept swinging his sword, unaware anyone had arrived.

Only after every pair of eyes around them had turned away did he murmur softly.

“Fate. Fate…”

His eyes lifted suddenly to the sky, empty. His next words were filled with nothing but bitterness.

“No. It’s all my fault.”

Then he turned his head abruptly and added,

“I’m sorry, Mukyung.”

As the man looked straight at him, the young man’s—Jin Mukyung’s—vision turned white.

Father.

At that moment—

Rrrrrumble.

The world around Jin Mukyung crumbled away. Brilliant light poured down from above, and a familiar voice reached his ears.

“Hey, you awake?”

Chapter 980

Jin Mukyung's wide-eyed expression was quite a sight.

Maybe that was because, in my memory, he was always so stiff and curt.

"Hey, you awake?"

I greeted him, glad to see him.

He was looking right at me, but the focus in his dazed eyes wavered.

"F-Father…"

Maybe he'd been unconscious for too long. His voice was so hoarse that the word faded before he could finish it.

Mukyung looked thoroughly confused. Beside me, Hyuk Mujin spoke up, worry plain on his face.

"Um, could there be something wrong with his head?"

"That's strange. The Medicine King Hall Master examined him and said there wasn't much to worry about."

"Even monkeys fall from trees. The Medicine King Hall Master might be one of the best physicians in Shanxi Province, but he can still make a mistake. He's getting on in years, too."

"Hmm. You think so?"

"To be honest, I had a bad feeling about him. Isn't he the old geezer who threatens to ram a giant needle into a patient's Huiyin Acupoint[3556] if they refuse treatment? Captain, don't you remember when he pulled that on you while we were trading blows with the Mount Heng Sword Sect?"

Of course I remembered.

The Medicine King Hall Master had been terrifying when he'd announced he was going to perform a forced opening ceremony with a needle as thick as my forearm.

Still, for all his temper, he seemed to know his stuff.

I'd checked Mukyung myself several times, too.

There were limits to examining someone's insides by channeling internal energy into them. Even taking that into account, though, his condition wasn't all that serious.

Not for someone who'd just fought a Supreme Peak master a level above him.

"Go get the Medicine King Hall Master first. Oh, and if you can…"

"I'll bring Great Hero Jeok too, if possible. Right?"

"Yeah."

That kid was quick on the uptake. These days, he knew what I meant before I even finished saying it.

[3556] Huiyin is an acupuncture point on the perineum, between the genitals and anus.

Hyuk Mujin gave a small bow and turned away. He was just about to take his first step when—

“Where… am I?”

His lips were cracked like drought-stricken fields. His voice came out in broken, hoarse bursts.

But it was too soon to relax.

His eyes were only beginning to focus again, so I cautiously waved my hand in front of them.

“Can you see this?”

“I can… see it. But where am I…?”

“Where do you think? The Jin Family of Taiyuan.”

“If that’s… the case…”

I could guess what he was trying to ask. Since he was struggling to get the words out, I gave him the answer he wanted most.

“We won.”

“Ah.”

“The nomads who were left surrendered to us completely, and everyone in the Murong Family was either killed or captured.”

“What about… the others?”

His questions kept coming, one after another. I pretended not to hear and ignored them.

I couldn’t tell him yet.

Not yet.

“I’ll tell you later.”

“What?”

“Look at you. Your eyes are still out of it. Tell me how many fingers I’m holding up.”

Mukyung knew better than anyone that he hadn’t fully come around. I held up three fingers, slipping the change of subject in while he frowned at me.

“Three.”

“Good. And now?”

“Five.”

He answered both without hesitation. His head seemed to be clearing.

But the most important final step remained.

With a grave expression, I took off my shoe and stuck out my toes.

“And now?”

Mukyung was quiet for a moment. Then he spoke, his voice astonishingly firm.

“Move your filthy foot before I kill you.”

"Hmm. Perfect. Feeling more like yourself now, patient?"

Mukyung let out a shallow sigh.

"Yeah, you son of a bitch."

"Now, now. You can't talk like that to your own brother. Spit while lying down, and it'll land on your own face."

I didn't bother adding *though in reality, I was an outsider with not a drop of their blood in me.*

At least in the world I was living in now—Murim—the three sons of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been born to the same parents.

But at that teasing remark, an odd swirl of emotion surfaced on Mukyung's face for the briefest moment.

"What? Why are you looking at me like that?"

"None of your business. I just…"

Mukyung hesitated.

"I just had a strange dream."

"A strange dream? A nightmare?"

"Not quite a nightmare… I don't know. It was strange. That's all."

He still looked a little confused, but I shrugged it off.

Well, it happens. I have all kinds of dreams every time I pass out.

I was used to it.

No—maybe it was one of the chronic problems shared by Hunters and Murim people alike.

Keep coming close to death, and your state of mind is bound to change. That unease often comes out in dreams.

"So, how do you feel?"

"How do I feel…"

Mukyung tried to sit up too quickly and frowned.

"Broken bones. Three, from what I can tell."

I nodded, satisfied. A patient who could feel the pain and assess his own condition was showing a good sign.

"Exactly. That matches the Medicine King Hall Master's diagnosis."

"My muscles hurt so much I can't even move. It feels like someone tore every muscle in my body to shreds."

"Of course you're in pain. You fought like a maniac. Perfectly normal."

"My internal injury… For some reason, it's not as bad as I expected."

I puffed out my chest, as if I'd been waiting for him to say that.

"I put in a little effort."

"You did?"

“Yep. You can thank me.”

Mukyung stared at me for a while, then nodded.

“I see.”

“That’s it?”

“Yeah.”

“Hmm. Strange. People who were raised right usually say thank you in a situation like this.”

“…Didn’t you just say something about spitting while lying down?”

“Me? When?”

I put on an innocent, confused expression. Mukyung sighed softly.

“Thank you.”

“I don’t feel any sincerity.”

“Thank you. I mean it.”

“Hmm. Somehow it feels like I’m making you bow down and thank me.”

“…”

“Let’s call that practice. One more time, and mean it this time.”

Mukyung took a deep breath.

“I survived thanks to you. I’m truly grateful.”

I wanted to tease him some more, but the look in his eyes told me I’d better stop there. Hiding my disappointment, I patted his shoulder.

“Good. That’s more like it. I’ll pass along your thanks.”

“Even after all this time, you’re exactly the same… What? Pass them along? What do you mean?”

“It’s nothing. Don’t worry about it. Some people helped treat your internal injury, that’s all.”

“Helped? Who?”

“They’re here. The Fire King and the Bow Saint. They’re both pretty nice people.”

“…?”

“Oh, right. You passed out early, so you wouldn’t know. Somehow, they ended up coming with me.”

Mukyung had seen Jeok Cheongang while I was staying with the Jin Family of Taiyuan. But hearing that the Bow Saint was here, too, must have been a shock in his weakened state.

He struggled to steady his ragged breathing before forcing out his next words.

“The Bow Saint? The one I know?”

“Yeah.”

“The Bow Saint from the Great Faction War? The one who uses a bow?”

“Ah. I thought so too, but if you mess with that bow, it turns into a pair of blades. Kind of like a transforming robot. Pretty amazing the first time you see it.”

“A crippled old servant…?”

“No, not a disabled old servant. A transforming robot. Though you probably wouldn’t understand even if I explained it.”

As expected, Mukyung hadn’t understood a word. He gave me a flat look.

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“Forget it. Let’s move on.”

“Fine. That’s probably for the best. So this crippled old servant you mentioned… No, the Bow Saint. You mean the one I know, one of the Three Saints?”

His words were starting to trip over themselves. I kindly nodded.

“Exactly.”

“…How did you even meet them?”

“At the Imperial Palace.”

“The Imperial Palace?”

“Yeah. The very same Imperial Palace everyone in the land knows about.”

“No, how did you get *there*?”

“It’s a long story, so I’ll give you the short version.”

Mukyung looked even more confused than when he’d first woken up. For his sake, I quickly organized the events in my brilliant mind and gave him a brief summary.

First: I went to the Imperial Palace and met the Emperor. It was a pretty scary place.

Second: We all pulled together and defeated the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

Third: Right afterward, I learned about the conspiracy surrounding Shanxi Province. The Emperor gave me an official post and even saw me off.

“…And that’s what happened. Got it?”

Hyuk Mujin, who’d listened to my clear and concise explanation, muttered under his breath.

“My diary from when I was six was more detailed than that.”

Mukyung, who’d stared blankly through the whole story, finally spoke.

“Are you actually insane?”

Hmm.

Ordinary people who couldn’t understand the thought process of a genius were everywhere.

In any case, after hearing the bare minimum, Jin Mukyung finally understood the situation and nodded.

“So those two treated my internal injury.”

“Right. They lived up to their reputations.”

“And you got thanked even though you did nothing.”

“Nothing? They’re my connections. I accepted your thanks on their behalf, as their representative.”

“Do you know something?”

“No. How would I? I haven’t said anything yet.”

“Sometimes, talking to you makes me feel like I’m losing my mind.”

“I’m a pretty cheerful guy. Ordinary people can’t always handle it.”

I flashed him a deliberately obnoxious grin. A bitter smile touched Mukyung’s lips.

“Is that all?”

“What?”

“I asked if that’s the only reason you’re pretending to be even cheerier than usual. Talking nonstop. Acting restless.”

I scratched the back of my head.

“Who knows? I’m not sure what you’re getting at.”

“It reminds me of two years ago. I came back to the family after a long time, and the hopeless good-for-nothing had become a completely different person.”

“…”

“The sudden change was strange, but deep down, I was a little happy. The youngest seemed to have been reborn as someone entirely new, and the more I got to know him, the more decent he seemed.”

Mukyung added, “At the very least, he wasn’t someone who’d laugh and chatter thoughtlessly while leaving behind the deaths and sacrifices of so many people.”

The corners of my mouth, which I’d forced upward, slackened.

Mukyung looked straight at me as my smile disappeared.

“You know you can’t avoid this any longer. So tell me the truth.”

The air grew heavy. My face, gone stiff, was reflected in his wavering eyes.

“Who was it, and how many people were sacrificed?”

Chapter 981

Jin Mukyung didn't know how much time had passed.

After his younger brother had told him everything, a long silence followed. In the end, there was only one thing Mukyung could say.

"I'm tired."

And so he was left alone.

He forced his aching body upright, leaned against the bed, and stared blankly out the window.

In the first light spreading from the distant east, he watched his younger brother leave the pavilion with a subordinate. The words he'd heard a moment ago came back to him.

Five thousand.

Just two syllables. Far too short to hold the weight of thousands of lives. The number didn't feel real.

But it was, without a doubt, reality.

Over three thousand died. The rest suffered injuries, big and small, and many were left crippled.

Of the fifteen thousand people of Shanxi who'd gathered at Eight Spring Gorge that day, a third had been killed or wounded.

Many of the casualties were government soldiers from the Shanxi Provincial Office, relatively weak in martial arts. But Mukyung knew they, too, were part of *us*—people who had put down roots and made their lives on this land.

…A great victory.

Yeah. A great victory. One for the history books.

More than five thousand casualties, yet in a single night they'd annihilated an army of well over thirty thousand.

They'd won an incredible victory against foreign enemies who outnumbered and overpowered them. It was no exaggeration to say they'd written a new page in the history of the Great Nation.

And yet, not a single person looked happy as they spoke of the great victory.

Those who took what belonged to others reveled in their victories. But those who fought to protect what was theirs mourned what they'd lost along the way.

The bodies and blood left behind by the dead were a burden the survivors alone had to bear.

The Hebei Peng Family lost more than half its forces. Great Hero Peng, the Thunderbolt Saber King, still hasn't regained consciousness.

The great tiger of the Peng Family, which had held sway over Hebei for so long, had yet to wake from his grievous injuries.

No one could have anticipated that the North Heaven Demon Lord—someone he'd considered a friend—would betray him. And the martial arts he'd used in his sudden ambush were in no way inferior to those of the Thunderbolt Saber King.

Even after we took down Jamukha and the North Heaven Demon Lord, things didn't go smoothly. If we hadn't subdued the nomads, we would probably have suffered much heavier losses.

Despite having joined the battlefield some time before, the Murong Family's forces had remained relatively intact until the fighting was nearly over.

If Jamukha had lived to see it, he would have realized the truth too late—and trembled.

Just as he'd used Temur to put the tribes of the eastern steppe in front as human shields, the North Heaven Demon Lord had used Jamukha to keep the Murong Family's losses to a minimum.

The law of the strong preying on the weak applied everywhere.

That's when the final battle began.

Sensing their end, the Murong Family fought with everything they had.

While their allies were dying all around them, they took the Temporary Strength Pill they'd held back until then and fought to open an escape route alongside the western steppe nomads who'd refused to abandon their cause even after Jamukha's death.

Together, they numbered a staggering five thousand.

The people of Shanxi and the Hebei Peng Family were exhausted from the long battle, however high their spirits remained. Thousands of enemies, strengthened beyond their limits, scattered in every direction to avoid the three Supreme Peak masters. They tore through the weakened encirclement and fled.

No—they tried to flee.

Then, beyond the faint dawn light pushing through the darkness, came a roar that shook the whole world.

Three forces appeared beneath banners that should never have been here.

We didn't expect them either. They arrived much sooner than we thought.

They said the scent of plum blossoms from Huashan filled the ridge in place of the Double Ninth Festival[3557] chrysanthemums, soaked in blood and stripped of their fragrance.

A force with a hundred Peak masters at its head charged beneath the Murim Alliance banner and swept through the enemy. Other new arrivals entered the narrow gorge, where quiet had fallen after the terrible fighting.

Their brilliant golden armor gleamed as they rode like the wind.

[3557]The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month. Chrysanthemums are traditionally associated with it.

The world called them the Embroidered Uniform Guard.[3558]

And that was the end of it.

A dense fog of blood rolled over the gorge and engulfed the broad basin.

With the first light of dawn, reinforcements swept in from every direction and crushed the enemy. The Bow Saint and the Fire King dominated the battlefield, while Jin Taekyung drove his spearhead into the chest of Murong Wijin, Head Elder of the Murong Family, who had resisted until the very end.

The battle—the war—ended that day.

Its beginning and end marked by the Double Ninth Festival.[3559]

It left behind the joy of a great victory, and a sorrow heavier still.

Three full days had passed since then. Mukyung had finally regained consciousness, and his younger brother had told him everything that had happened. Now Taekyung was walking away, growing smaller beyond the window.

Before he left, he'd left behind an old book.

He asked me to give it to you. No—to hyung.[3560]

Remembering the last words Taekyung had tossed out on his way through the door, Mukyung blinked like someone only just waking from sleep.

"…Ah."

A stifled groan escaped him.

His vision slowly clouded over. Taekyung was no longer in sight.

Only the four characters on the cover of the book resting on his knees remained clear.

Shura Annihilating Fist.

It was the last trace an old master had left in this world—and the legacy of his martial lineage, entrusted to the Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

Another casualty of the battle three days ago. A man who had fought back-to-back with Mukyung but had not survived.

Great Hero Cheol.

Mukyung thought of Cheol Mubaek, the Tiger of Mount Heng.

Cheol had risked his life to buy him a moment against the formidable Demon Bird.

Mukyung remembered his last smile, blood staining his bared teeth. And he remembered Cheol's voice from a day two years earlier, when the man had approached him as he was leaving the Mount Heng Sword Sect and spoken as though making a joke.

[3558] The Embroidered Uniform Guard was an imperial guard and security institution in dynastic China.

[3559] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month. Chrysanthemums are traditionally associated with it.

[3560] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"I hear you're crazy about martial arts."

"Pardon?"

"So, I was wondering—are you interested in Seowol?"

"I'm sorry, what are you talking about all of a sudden…?"

"Exactly what I said. I don't have much, so I can't offer you gold or silver. But if the two of you got together, I'd gladly give you the Shura Annihilating Fist manual…"

"Uncle Cheol!"

"Goodness, you'll burst my eardrums. You've only just become Sect Leader, and you're already trying to boss me around?"

It was strange.

Mukyung had thought Cheol was someone whose path had merely crossed his own. Why, then, could he remember that hearty laugh so clearly?

Why did a heavy ache press against his chest?

So that's what this is.

Only then did he recognize the emotions gripping him.

Sorrow. Anger. And…

Guilt over what he'd already lost.

If I'd been stronger. If I'd been just a little stronger that day.

He could have protected them. Saved more people.

But he hadn't.

He'd fought with everything he had, swinging his sword without rest through a pitch-black darkness where a day felt like ten years. Still, he hadn't been able to reach them.

If it had been you instead of me—no, both of you—everything would have been different.

Meeting Cheongpung had made him feel, for the first time, that there was a wall he could not cross.

Watching Jin Taekyung improve at an astonishing pace had rekindled a longing that had faded within him.

He'd been called a genius since the day he first picked up a sword. Only after seeing what those two were truly capable of had he understood: if his talent was a gift from Heaven, theirs was talent they'd taken from it.

What do I… What do I have to do to reach you? To keep from losing anyone else?

Emotions he couldn't put into words swirled inside him.

He was staring out the window where his brother had disappeared when—

Tap.

A faint sound came from the crack around the firmly shut door.

Then a familiar voice reached him.

“Hey, Mujin. Remember that time?”

Mukyung’s eyes widened. He’d thought his brother had gone. An answer followed, so stiff it sounded unnatural.

“Um. W-Which time do you mean?”

“You know. When we formed that recon squad and were busting our asses.”

“Oh. Ah, yes. I remember.”

“Yeah, I saw a lot of things I wish I hadn’t back then. I just… at some point, I got so angry at how pathetic I was. Why was I only capable of this much? Why did people whose faces I’d gotten to know in passing have to die?”

“…”

“But you know what pissed me off the most?”

On the other side of the door, Taekyung leaned against it and went on as if talking to himself.

“No matter how hard I fucking try, I can’t get used to it. Nothing changes.”

Mukyung’s eyes trembled.

Forgetting even the pain, he clenched his fist as hard as he could and squeezed his eyes shut. Taekyung’s voice kept coming through the door.

“It’s always the same. I thought if I got stronger than I am now, I could stop bad things from happening. I thought once I could use Sword Energy and send out Force whenever I wanted, nothing as shitty as what happened back then would happen again…”

A low sigh slipped through the crack.

“But no. Every time, I still feel like shit. I was asking for too much.”

More. More. More.

The stronger a person became, the more they wanted. Their hopes grew grander, and their sense of responsibility swelled until it felt ready to burst.

Mukyung thought of himself as a boy, endlessly swinging a sword simply because he loved it.

Had that boy felt anything like the responsibility he felt now?

Back then, all he’d had was talent. He hadn’t even thought about restoring his family’s fortunes.

Taekyung’s voice reached him again.

“But I know this much. If we give up, it ends here.”

Taekyung no longer waited for an answer. Hyuk Mujin’s awkward attempts to play along had stopped, too.

The voice continued as though its words were meant for someone else.

“We just have to keep trying. Do the best we can with what we can do right now. If you despair and give up because nothing changes, that’s when hell really begins.

Because later, you realize that all the effort you put in meant fewer people were taken from you.”

“…!”

“So just keep doing what you’ve been doing. Keep at it, like you always have.”

The bitterness in Taekyung’s voice slowly faded. A brief silence fell.

Then something whistled fiercely through the air.

Whoosh—thwack!

“Ow! Why’d you hit me?”

“Answer me, you bastard. When someone’s talking, you’re supposed to give them something back. Don’t make it awkward.”

“Seriously? You’re not even talking to me anyw—Mmph! Mmph!”

At the muffled sounds and the scrape of something being dragged away, Mukyung smiled faintly.

Then, in a voice clear enough to pass through the crack around the door, he saw the uninvited visitors off as they left the pavilion.

“Thank you. Truly.”

Their footsteps paused, as though they’d heard him. Then they quickly faded away.

Chapter 982

I’m a selfish bastard.

As long as the people around me and I can be happy, I don’t much care what happens elsewhere.

But every now and then, I notice that somewhere along the way, I’ve changed.

Like when I put on a ridiculous little show because I couldn’t stop worrying about someone who was beating himself up and crying.

“Sometimes, when I look at you, Captain, I think…”

It had been a while since I’d fled the pavilion, practically running away from Jin Mukyung.

We were walking in silence when Hyuk Mujin spoke up. I cut him off.

“Don’t think. No, just don’t talk.”

“Why not?”

“Because I don’t want to hear it.”

“It’s not because you’re embarrassed, is it?”

He was right.

That was why I’d been trying so hard to ignore the way Hyuk Mujin kept staring at me.

“It’s just…”

“Just?”

“I somehow felt concerned, so I stuck my nose in where it didn’t belong. That’s all.”

The words I’d said to Jin Mukyung through the door were also the conclusion I’d reached after a long time thinking about it.

I didn’t know if it was the right answer. If it could comfort him even a little right now, that was enough.

In the end, time and experience solved most problems.

An answer wasn’t something someone else could hand you. You had to find it yourself.

For him, this is only the first step.

He was an unparalleled genius born of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and in this world, at least, he was my older brother. But Jin Mukyung was only in his mid-twenties.

He’d spent his life honing his martial arts. He could count his experiences in real combat on one hand, and he wasn’t used to the loss that came with them.

If a few embarrassing words could bring him even a little comfort, I’d say them dozens or hundreds of times.

Jin Mukyung's heart and his feet were pointed toward the righteous path, without a hair's breadth of deviation.

The more he grew, the more livable the world would become.

Walk. Don't sit down. Keep walking, and walking, and walking.

At the end of that road was an answer.

There was light.

I believed that.

With all my heart.

"But, Captain. Can I tell you something?"

"What?"

"This is the wrong way. If we keep going, we'll hit a dead end."

I was silent for a moment, then looked at Hyuk Mujin in disbelief.

"Wait… Why are you only telling me now, you bastard?"

"Well, you suddenly got this intense look in your eyes and started making a cool face."

"…"

I wanted to hit him.

I really did.

Too much had happened over the past three days for me to tell Jin Mukyung everything.

A great battle, with tens of thousands of allies and enemies tangled together.

Three days had already passed since the people of Shanxi won their great victory, but the battle had left a staggering mess behind.

When uninvited guests show up and leave a place filthy and wrecked, the cleanup falls to the homeowner.

From the day of our victory, Jin Wikyung had more work than ten people could handle. Before he'd even recovered from the battle, he had to begin dealing with its aftermath.

Of course, the people around him weren't going to stand by and let him do that.

"I'm going to give the Lesser Family Head three choices. Hear them all before you pick one."

The first to step in was the Medicine King Hall Master.

At a glance, he looked like a stubborn old man. But with a menacing gleam in his eyes that didn't match his calm tone, he glanced back and forth between the long needle in his hand and Jin Wikyung, then said:

“You can keep ignoring my orders and working until you ruin your health and die. Or you can get treated now, take it easy, and live a long life. Or, if you’d rather not drag it out, you can die by my hand. Which will it be?”

Only then did Jin Wikyung begin to get some proper rest. Everyone who’d witnessed the exchange fiercely debated what they’d seen behind his back.

Had his face gone as pale as a corpse’s from exhaustion, or from the Medicine King Hall Master’s long needle?

Hyuk Mujin put it plainly.

“The needle. No question. Didn’t you see that old man’s eyes? If he hadn’t studied medicine, he’d have a position in Dark Heaven by now.”

What mattered was that Jin Wikyung had relented. Others had helped make that possible, too.

“That quack who calls himself the Medicine King Hall Master is absolutely right. You focus on recovering. The others will take care of what’s left.”

We’d won the battle on the Double Ninth Festival[3561], but we still couldn’t be sure every threat was gone.

Even so, the presence of a giant like the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was enough to wash away the slightest worry.

So was the Bow Saint, who had finally appeared before people again after decades.

“I’ll go to Hebei.”

The Bow Saint left as soon as the battle ended, with only those few words.

Peng Cheolyeong—the Thunderbolt Saber King’s son, the current Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family, and the Iron Blood Saber—had no choice but to take the family members fit to travel and return to Hebei with her.

It was only natural.

The North Heaven Demon Lord—no, Murong Baek—hadn’t betrayed us alone.

That meant the entire Murong Family had joined Dark Heaven. Two days later, a messenger eagle arrived at the Jin Family of Taiyuan with news confirming part of what we’d suspected.

“As we expected, there was trouble in Hebei.”

Several people had forced Jin Wikyung to rest, but getting the paperwork out of his hands was nearly impossible.

The instant the messenger eagle arrived at the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Jin Wikyung received the news. He immediately called me in and told me what had happened in Hebei.

“It seems the Murong Family targeted both Shanxi and Hebei from the start. They used their offer to support us as a pretext to cross Hebei, leaving some of their forces behind to ambush the Peng Family.”

[3561] The Double Ninth Festival, or Chongyang Festival, falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

The bloodshed on the Double Ninth Festival[3562] hadn't been confined to Shanxi Province.

The Hebei Peng Family had been caught completely off guard by the Murong Family's betrayal. With the Thunderbolt Saber King and many of their strongest masters away, they'd suffered heavy losses and had barely managed to defend their family home, fighting to the death.

"But even that would only have bought them time. If everything had been delayed by two days, something irreversible would have happened."

But just as the family stood on the brink of ruin, Peng Cheolyeong, its Family Head, finally arrived.

Peng Cheolyeong announced himself with a roar. Behind him came some five hundred family members who'd returned from Shanxi at his side, along with hundreds of martial artists from the Jinzhou Yan Family, who were effectively vassals of the Hebei Peng Family.

If that had been all, the battle would have been a hard one for the Hebei Peng Family.

The surprise attack had already devastated the Hebei Peng Family, and the thousand troops Peng Cheolyeong had assembled in haste were exhausted.

But at their head stood a giant whom even Peng Cheolyeong, Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family, would not dare step ahead of.

"Once Senior Bow Saint made up her mind, the outcome was as good as decided."

It was another victory for us—and a terrible defeat for the Murong Family.

The kind of defeat they could never recover from.

And so the Murong Family was annihilated.

Several dozen enemies, including its Lesser Family Head, Murong Yeonghwi, barely escaped the battlefield and vanished. But who knew?

"Unless they have a Moving Formation hidden somewhere, they'll be caught soon enough. We have eyes everywhere."

Jin Wikyung wasn't boasting.

Even if the dark clouds cast by Dark Heaven eventually covered everyone's heads, for now, the orthodox Murim factions still ruled the land.

The Murong Family had made an enemy of the world.

They couldn't flee into the vast Central Plains without breaking through the Jin Family of Taiyuan and the Hebei Peng Family. To the east, the Great Nation's warships guarded the open sea.

And the Great Steppe—their roots and little more than the final destination for outlaws—was already practically under the Jin Family of Taiyuan's control.

[3562]The Double Ninth Festival, or Chongyang Festival, falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

“Send your tribespeople after them. Hunt them to the ends of the earth if you have to.”

It wasn’t a request.

As Shanxi’s Alliance Leader, the victor of the great battle, and the master who had brought a defeated hunting dog to heel, Jin Wikyung gave his first order.

“You don’t want to leave yourself trouble later, either. Do you, Temur?”

“I… will obey.”

The young chieftain who had once dreamed of uniting the vast steppe as its Great Khan submitted helplessly.

Of course he did.

He was a commander defeated in battle, and a coward who had betrayed his brothers and tribespeople for fear of death.

For his defeat, he’d been given a pretext: Jamukha and the North Heaven Demon Lord had drawn him into their schemes. He’d also been given the false absolution of having prevented greater losses by submitting to the Jin Family of Taiyuan. His betrayal was another matter.

If the whole truth came out, Temur would die.

Not at our hands or Dark Heaven’s. At the hands of his own tribespeople.

That was the leash Jin Wikyung held tight. The hunting dog couldn’t even think of betraying him.

From the moment Temur accepted Jin Wikyung’s offer and joined the attack on the Murong Family, every other choice had effectively disappeared.

It’s disgusting, but now that we’re holding his leash, we need him on our side.

How many lives had Temur’s petty cowardice and instinct for survival cost?

“Go. Just looking at you pisses me off.”

Temur lowered his head at my contemptuous words and left. I called over the man who could deal with the remaining problem once and for all.

“You called?”

His brilliant golden armor drew every eye wherever he went.

His expression and manner of speaking were as stiff as the helmet tucked under his arm.

I deliberately frowned at Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

“What’s with you? Why do you look so fine?”

“Because I fought well.”

“Or did you just show up at the end and take all the credit?”

“Is that what you say to a Benefactor who traveled thousands of li[3563] to help you?”

[3563] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi).

“Hey, remember who helped you first. What would you have done at the Imperial Palace without me?”

“What would I have done? The Bow Saint would have helped.”

“…Huh. Now that I think about it, you’re right.”

“…I didn’t expect you to admit that.”

Silence settled between us for a moment. Then, as if on cue, we both chuckled.

I’d been teasing him for no reason, but I was grateful to the guy.

He was grateful to me, and I felt the same way about him.

“I called you because I have a favor to ask.”

“A favor?”

“Yeah. It might be a little difficult. No, very difficult.”

“Someone might die.”

I nodded quietly. Jeong Hogun answered without a moment’s hesitation.

“Then I refuse.”

“Ah.”

His tone was as sharp as a blade.

I swallowed a groan at the unexpected refusal. Then he continued in a low voice.

“An order.”

“What?”

“I can’t grant a personal favor. An order is different.”

I finally understood what he meant and let out a short laugh.

“Why go this far?”

“Because that is the Great Nation’s military code.”

What an interesting guy.

And for a moment, I thought: perhaps the Great Nation could exist because it had people like Jeong Hogun.

So I gave him what he wanted.

“Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.”

As though our conversation had never happened, Jeong Hogun respectfully bowed his head.

“Give your order.”

“Lead the Embroidered Uniform Guard under your command to Liaoning.”

Liaoning Province.

The Murong Family’s stronghold, and the last threat left to deal with.

At my order, Jeong Hogun struck his armor.

“I obey the Marquis of Shangshan’s command.”

Chapter 983

By the time the thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards led by Jeong Hogun crossed Hebei and reached Liaoning Province, everyone in the region knew the truth. Not just the martial artists—even the common people.

The nomads' invasion. The Murong Family's betrayal.

And, finally, Dark Heaven lurking behind it all.

Not even the most hot-blooded martial artist dared stand in the Embroidered Uniform Guard's way. There were two main reasons.

First was the force and authority of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, among the Great Nation's finest troops. Second was the banner flying beside the imperial flag.

The Murim Alliance.

Even a renowned veteran of the martial world who had loudly insisted that martial artists should handle Murim affairs themselves would have had no choice but to accept it quietly before the Murim Alliance's towering banner.

The two great powers guiding the world had joined forces. All that remained was to punish the Murong Family.

Before long, everyone's attention turned to one place.

Shenyang, Liaoning Province.

The Murong Family's ancestral estate. They had once thundered across the continent with a charging spear and a composite bow and founded a nation.

Now they faced ruin.

"Surround it."

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Jeong Hogun's terse command shook the earth.

There was no need for all thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards to take action.

The authority of the Marquis of Shangshan, personally appointed by the Son of Heaven not long ago, was vast enough to encompass the entire northern frontier. And when the Embroidered Uniform Guard—the force said to knock birds from the sky—arrived, Liaoning Province's City Lord had rushed out to greet them and immediately surrendered all the military authority at his disposal.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

The first thousand cavalrymen galloped out to surround the Murong Family estate. Heavily armored infantry filled every gap with shields, spears, and swords.

Finally, the archers took their positions. Everything was ready.

Like any Murim family on the frontier, the Murong Family estate was a fortress made by nature itself. And now it was sealed off without a single gap.

Grrrrrr.

With a heavy grinding sound, the iron gate slowly began to open.

A man dressed in white as snow appeared beyond it. Jeong Hogun spoke.

“Loose.”

There was not a moment’s hesitation in the order.

The archers were already in formation, ready to fire.

Fwoosh!

For an instant, part of the sky turned black. Hundreds of arrows tore through the air toward the man in white, and he hastily swung his sword.

Clang-clang-clang!

Steel struck steel, scattering sparks.

When the rain of arrows had swept past the gate, the man stood there looking shaken. From behind him came anguished cries.

“Young Master!”

“You mustn’t! Please, come back!”

“What are you doing? Bring the Young Master back—!”

Instead of answering, the man waved them back. He bit his lip, fixed his gaze on Jeong Hogun in the distance, and took a heavy step forward.

Step.

Jeong Hogun watched him in silence, then spoke again.

“Loose.”

Another rain of arrows fell. The sword flashed.

This time, blood spattered the ground.

Drip. Drip.

The shoulder pierced by an arrow twitched, but the man kept walking. He did not stop even when arrows from the third volley drove into him in several places.

Thwack!

At last, his knees buckled. His once-white clothes had long since turned red.

The family retainers could bear it no longer and rushed out through the gate. Yet there was not a trace of pain in his shout.

“Stop! Have you all forgotten my orders?”

“B-but—!”

“Don’t come any closer! Whatever happens, you must not act rashly!”

The family members who had started to run through the gate clenched their teeth and stopped.

The man gave a small nod, then leaned on his sword and staggered to his feet.

At last, he faced Jeong Hogun, who was riding slowly toward him.

“We finally meet. It seems risking my life was worth it.”

Jeong Hogun looked down at him quietly from the saddle.

Up close, he could see that the man was barely twenty.

“Are you of the Murong bloodline?”

“I am. My father committed an unforgivable wrong.”

They said blood could not lie.

Looking at the young man’s distinctly foreign features, Jeong Hogun suddenly recalled a face he had seen while collecting the dead, just after the fierce battle around Eight Spring Gorge had ended.

“Then you’re Murong Baek’s…?”

“His seventh son, born in his old age. The son of a father burdened with sin.”

The young man answered calmly and cupped his hands in greeting.

“I am Murong Su, the Murong Family’s Seventh Young Master. I greet you, Thousand Captain Jeong.”

“You know me.”

“I have eyes and ears. I’d heard you were coming.”

“Then why did you stay?”

“If I fled like my elder brothers, I would be admitting that I was a traitor and an enemy of Murim.”

“Staying changes nothing. But let’s hear your second reason.”

The young man, Murong Su, lowered his hands and lifted his head.

His gaze at Jeong Hogun was clear, and his voice was calm.

“Someone has to take responsibility, don’t they?”

“…Responsibility.”

“I’m the only direct descendant left at the estate. Everyone involved has either died or fled.”

Jeong Hogun studied him in silence beneath the brim of his helmet, then looked past his shoulder.

“Then who are those people who stayed with you?”

“I don’t know if you’ll believe me, but they, too, were betrayed by my father. And they aren’t people who could really be called members of the Murong bloodline.”

Jeong Hogun could guess who they were.

People so isolated within the family that they could never have learned the truth. Distant branches of distant branches, perhaps, or people who had never fit in. There would also be former guests who had become part of the Murong Family without sharing a drop of its blood.

All but one.

“Did you not know about your father’s crimes, either?”

“I can’t say I knew. Nor can I say I didn’t. I had only a vague feeling that something was wrong.”

“And?”

“I simply watched from a distance.”

“Was it your affection for your own blood?”

“I don’t know when I was ever considered part of the Murong Family. My mother was a barbarian, my birth lowly, and my martial talent nothing worth speaking of…”

Murong Su smiled bitterly.

“But one thing I do know. Saving those who remain is the best I can do.”

“So in the end, you’re the only one left. Murong Su, Murong Baek’s son. A traitor’s blood.”

“That’s right. So, the others—”

“Execute them on the spot.”

At Jeong Hogun’s firm interruption, all color drained from Murong Su’s face.

“What do you—”

“The Murong Family Head, Murong Baek, and his family colluded with foreign enemies, disrupted the order of the Great Nation, and caused immense harm throughout the northern frontier. This was clearly an act of treason. Not the slightest mercy can be shown in punishing it.”

“Thousand Captain!”

Blood mingled with the cry he forced out.

Crack. Murong Su snapped the arrows lodged in his body, his face contorted with anguish.

“I told you! They—they…!”

He coughed up blood and fell to his knees before he could finish.

The retainers, who had watched it all from a distance, could bear no more. They rushed out through the iron gate.

“Young Master!”

“No! The Young Master has done nothing wrong!”

As they ran toward him, crying out in desperation, Jeong Hogun slowly raised a hand.

In Murong Su’s wide eyes, hundreds of archers drew their bowstrings taut.

There was no choice left.

One small gesture. Or one short command.

That would end it. Everything.

“N-no! Please, stop!”

Murong Su’s desperate plea burst out with a spray of dark red blood.

And then, a hoarse old voice spoke from behind Jeong Hogun.

“People only show their true hearts when their lives are in danger. Don’t you agree, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard?”

The speaker was a small old man with dark skin and distinctive features unlike

those of a Han[3564] man.

But what made him truly unusual was his mount. He rode neither a horse nor a mule, but a person.

A huge man who might have rivaled a bear.

“Taishan can’t understand what you’re saying. Has Namho gone senile?”

“Damn you. Not again.”

The old man, Namho, was unfazed.

As if he had been waiting for the moment, he pulled out a chunk of jerky and stuffed it into Taishan’s mouth. Then he nodded toward Jeong Hogun.

“Anyway. In this old man’s opinion, this is probably enough for now. What do you think?”

Jeong Hogun thought for a moment, then lowered his hand.

As his fingers slowly relaxed, hundreds of taut bowstrings lowered in silence.

“We’ll take them into custody and bring them to the government office first. Their fate will be decided after a thorough interrogation.”

“Do that. An old man like me couldn’t stop you from going that far. They should be grateful for even that much.”

Namho shrugged and patted the top of Taishan’s head.

The huge man crouched, bringing Namho roughly eye to eye with Murong Su. The young man could only blink, still unable to make sense of what was happening.

“You said your name was Murong Su?”

“Y-yes. But who are you, sir?”

“No need to know an old man’s name. Just know that I belong to the Murim Alliance.”

“The Murim Alliance…!”

“Oh, one more thing. Right now, I also represent the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—no, the Marquis of Shangshan.”

Namho smiled bitterly at Murong Su’s face, which had gone stiff as stone.

“Don’t look so surprised. I’m only offering you a chance.”

“A chance…?”

“Yes. A chance for those who haven’t strayed from the orthodox path.”

Namho knew.

No—Jin Taekyung knew.

There was light even in deep darkness, and darkness even in the brightest light.

That was why Jin Taekyung had sent Namho here.

[3564] Han refers to China’s majority ethnic group.

There was more than one way to eliminate a future threat. If what remained was not diseased plants but strong, green shoots, there was no reason to pull them up by the roots.

If we're the orthodox faction, shouldn't we at least live up to the name?

Remembering what Jin Taekyung had said before leaving the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Namho smiled faintly.

Then he addressed Murong Su and all the others who had come running, though barely a hundred of them remained.

"From this moment on, the Murong Family no longer exists."

"…!"

"Those who abandoned benevolence and righteousness and strayed from the orthodox path can no longer belong to the Murim Alliance's orthodox factions, nor can they be a great family."

His voice carried a force that seemed impossible for someone so small. Though he had put not a trace of internal energy into it, every word reached their ears clearly.

"But if any among you still walk the right path, the Murim Alliance will not cast you aside. That is the right thing to do."

Namho looked straight at Murong Su.

"As I said, the Murong Family no longer exists. The Murong household, however, is another matter."

This was not his decision alone. Every sect in the north and the Murim Alliance had agreed to it.

"If your innocence is proven in the future, the Murong family will have another chance to prove itself under a new Family Head."

"…!"

"…!"

At that moment, the hundred or so members of the family trembled.

They had thought everything was over. Now they had one last chance to clear their names and prove themselves—all because of the sacrifice and courage of the one man who had not abandoned them to the very end.

"Young Master!"

No longer retainers of the Murong Family but of the Murong household, they surrounded Murong Su with fervent voices and shining eyes.

The man they would soon call Family Head.

As Namho watched the scene with a calm gaze, he suddenly remembered something he had forgotten and smiled faintly.

The Five Great Families.

Together with the Nine Sects and One Gang, they were the fifteen pillars holding up the vast world of the Nine Provinces.

He already knew who would fill the vacant fifth seat left by the fall of the Murong name.

No—in fact, all the martial world knew.

Chapter 984

The saying that words without feet can travel a thousand *ri*[3565] was wrong. They could travel ten thousand—or even farther—in the blink of an eye.

The chain of events in the north spread with astonishing speed, and without end.

From person to person, on the beating wings of messenger eagles, and on the pounding hooves of horses driven by messengers' hurried whips.

Before long, the fallout from the truth that had come to light was enough to shake the entire Central Plains.

"How could the Murong Family…!"

"That's impossible. It can't be true!"

Disbelief was the first reaction of the martial artists who heard the news.

Of course it was.

The traitors exposed before the whole world weren't groups rooted in demonic, heterodox arts, like the Yangtze River Channel League or the Green Forest Alliance. They were none other than the Murong Family.

One of the Five Great Families.

Though based at the very edge of the north, it was a great family in the truest sense, renowned from the vast lands of Liaoning all the way to the Central Plains.

And yet that very Murong Family had supposedly joined forces with Dark Heaven.

Worse, it wasn't the work of a handful of rogue members. Most of the family, including its Family Head, Murong Baek, had been involved.

The shock this unbelievable news dealt to those who heard it was beyond words.

"The Family Head, the Divine Spear of the Imugi, distinguished himself in the Great Faction War. Why would he—or the Murong Family—do such a thing…?"

But their disbelief lasted only a moment.

The Beggars' Sect, the Lower District Sect, Huashan, and the Hebei Peng Family—

and the Murim Alliance, the heart of the martial world—

all officially confirmed that every word of it was true, without the slightest falsehood.

Even the giant beyond the martial world—who existed, yet might as well not have—confirmed it.

"Clear the way!"

Groups of government soldiers, some numbering dozens and others hundreds, swept through the land.

[3565] A Korean *ri* is about 393 m (0.244 mi). The opening uses a Korean proverb.

For so long, they had spent their days leaning against their spears, their faces slack with the ease of a lasting peace. Now, fully armed, they carried out their orders with sharp eyes beneath their helmets, watching every direction.

“Hey, what’s going on?”

“How should I know? But with things this tense, I’d guess it has something to do with whatever happened in the Imperial Capital recently.”

“Oh, I heard about that too. You mean those bastards called Dark Heaven? I heard from a martial artist I know that they went on another rampage…”

This wasn’t happening in just one place.

Seeing the soldiers’ sudden change in demeanor, people gathered, both bewildered and on edge.

Before long, they read the proclamations the soldiers had posted all around before leaving.

> Let it be known to all under Heaven, to all the people:

That was how the proclamation began. Men of letters in every province had written it in a single flowing hand. Pressed forward under the crowd’s gaze, the scholars reading it aloud found their voices trembling more and more as the recitation went on.

> “…Th-therefore, I shall join forces with the martial men outside government service to make an example of the traitorous band known as Dark Heaven. This is my will and Heaven’s decree.”

Even after the lengthy recitation ended, the gathering remained silent as the grave.

Those who understood the sudden proclamation stared wide-eyed, like the scholars reading it. The country folk who didn’t understand glanced about and whispered under their breath.

“What in the world does that mean?”

“I don’t rightly know. Seems like ‘martial men who don’t belong to the government’ means martial artists, though… Couldn’t they just say it plain? Why’d they have to write it so fancy?”

They lived from day to day, earning only enough to eat.

They had been born with little chance to learn anything but hard work and how to use their bodies. Their pockets were always light, while their shoulders bore the

[3566] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand *geun* is 600 kg (about 1,320 lb).

weight of a thousand *geun*.[3566] How could they be expected to read a line of writing?

But there were always people who couldn't stand silence or ignorance.

"It is an imperial decree personally issued by His Majesty. He has declared Dark Heaven a band of traitors and announced to all his people that he will join forces with the martial artists of the world to punish them."

Only then did people look down.

Beneath the tiny letters was a clear imprint of a seal.

It was the mark of the imperial seal, reserved for only one person in all the vast Nine Provinces—one that countless people had never even seen.

Even those who couldn't read could tell at a glance that it was no ordinary seal.

"This is more serious than I expected. They're even borrowing the martial world's swords and spears."

At the young scholar's sudden remark, someone else murmured with a sigh.

"I've heard all the rumors about Dark Heaven, but… I never thought it was this bad."

The first to hear news from every corner of the world were martial artists and merchants.

People outside those circles rarely had their ear to the ground unless they had special connections. And even when something happened, they generally saw no reason to worry.

The Great Nation stood on a firm foundation.

The countless purges and provincial warlord rebellions that had followed its founding were long over.

With the passage of time, the world had settled into peace. Even during the calamity some fifty years ago that martial artists called the Great Faction War, the common people had suffered almost no harm.

Why?

It was simple.

Even the fanatics from far to the west, who bore the chilling name of the Demonic Cult, had feared the Great Nation joining the war.

They had wanted it to be seen as nothing more than a struggle between martial-world factions.

But…

"This time will be different. Different from any other."

When Shaolin Temple's Abbot, once likened to a living Buddha, entered nirvana and the grounds where only the peaceful sound of wooden fish[3567] had once echoed ran red with blood, no one there had felt anything beyond sorrow.

[3567] A wooden fish is a wooden percussion instrument used to mark the rhythm of Buddhist chanting.

It was the same when they heard that the Daoists of Qingcheng and Emei, who seemed like immortals, had fallen, and that the Sichuan Tang Clan—whose people had a reputation for being a fearsome bunch even among ordinary folk—had suffered terrible losses.

That was the Murim everyone knew.

In that cruel forest, where spears and swords ran wild in place of green trees, even venerable monks and Daoists could die at any moment.

No, there was another reason they had watched it all without much concern.

Whatever happens, surely nothing will happen to us.

They lived in different worlds, behind different walls.

The people had entrusted their safety to the Great Nation's walls. All they had done was watch the martial artists fight their fierce battles in their own domain.

Now and then, they pitied the unlucky common folk caught up in Murim affairs and killed. But that was all.

A fire blazing hundreds of *li*[3568] away couldn't warm everyone.

The people's feelings and interest burned hot for a moment, then quickly cooled.

Compared to the whole, the victims were only a handful. The rest could wake up tomorrow just fine.

They had the Great Nation, a great and sturdy wall.

But that unshakable faith was crumbling at that very moment.

"W-wait, sirs. Then what you're saying is…"

Gulp.

The village elder couldn't finish. He only swallowed dryly, and the old scholar spoke in his place.

He spoke the truth no one wanted to believe or even hear.

The truth they had no choice but to face.

"That's right. It's exactly what you think."

He let out a quiet sigh.

The old scholar looked down at his wrinkled hands, etched with the marks of time.

He remembered when they had been white and smooth.

He remembered his younger self, with so many possibilities before him, unable to go any farther because an age of chaos refused to end. He remembered those turbulent years.

Slowly, he continued.

"The war has already begun."

"…!"

"…!"

[3568] A Chinese *li*, used for distances in this setting, is 500 m (0.311 mi).

Some clenched their teeth and fists. Others squeezed their eyes shut.

Soundless shock surged through the crowd like a wave.

The word *war* spread in every direction, carried in wide-open eyes and slackened lips.

Along broad avenues, through narrow, dark alleys, and with the hurried footsteps of those rushing to carry the unbelievable news onward.

War.

The flames of a great war that would burn everything.

At that moment, the old scholar saw it.

The darkness that had slumbered for so many years had finally awoken, painting everyone's faces with despair.

And suddenly, he repeated in his mind an unfamiliar name from the proclamation bearing the Son of Heaven's command.

Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

No—the Marquis of Shangshan, Jin Taekyung.

The foremost contributor to stopping this rebellion, a martial artist still so young, yet raised to the rank of marquis.

I don't know much about the affairs of the martial world… but one thing is certain.

The old scholar had once served in government. He could guess well enough what future awaited that young martial artist, who had achieved something without precedent—and something that would never happen again.

I don't know who you are, but please, give it everything you have and keep moving forward. Not only for the Murim you've always known, but for this country as well.

Though his words would never reach him, the old scholar bowed toward the proclamation.

First, to the Son of Heaven, who watched over all things from the distant Imperial Capital.

Second, to the countless heroic souls who would shed their blood and fall to protect this world.

And lastly, to the new marquis who stood at the heart of the martial world by virtue of the solemn imperial decree.

The old scholar continued to bow.

In full view of the crowd, he did so silently, offering all the respect and sincerity he could.

And thousands of *li*[3569] away, in a narrow gorge, bright yellow chrysanthemums colored the landscape in every direction.

[3569] A Chinese *li*, used for distances in this setting, is 500 m (0.311 mi).

I'd heard of the Double Ninth Festival[3570] a few times in passing, but that was about all I knew.

As a Korean born and raised, I'd always observed the big holidays like Lunar New Year and Chuseok.[3571] But I didn't have so much time on my hands that I could take an interest in the customs of those guys on the continent.

Today, though, I followed the customs of the Double Ninth Festival[3572] too.

I held more bright yellow chrysanthemums than my arms could contain, and awkwardly wore a pouch of cornelian berries at my side.

It was a way to honor those who had passed before they could celebrate the Double Ninth Festival[3573] themselves.

And we had to keep moving forward, leaving their sacrifice behind us.

Whoosh.

Wind from far away stirred the chrysanthemums in my arms.

It came out of nowhere and tugged insistently at them, as if taking them by the hand. Several petals, large and small, gave in and went along with it.

Before long, they fluttered through the air like a rain of flowers.

Riding the wind, they swam through the twists and turns of the Eight Spring Gorge, as those who had lived on this land long ago had named it.

Ah.

I swallowed the exclamation that almost escaped me.

It was beautiful and, at the same time, unbearably sad.

I wasn't the only one who felt it. Tens of thousands of people filled the Eight Spring Gorge, and I knew they felt it too.

Watching the yellow petals fall, I found myself wondering: Even now, as they drifted farther and farther away with the wind, were they only petals? Or were they the souls of those who had willingly thrown away their lives to protect what they cherished?

There was no single right answer.

There was no need to find one.

We could believe whatever we wanted to believe. Someday, we would return here and remember them.

Each in our own way.

With laughter. With chrysanthemums and cornelian berries.

Or…

With tears.

[3570] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

[3571] Chuseok is a Korean harvest festival celebrated on the fifteenth day of the eighth lunar month.

[3572] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

[3573] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Drip. Drip, drip.

Senses far beyond human limits sometimes told me things I didn’t want to know.

Like the tears wetting the leather shoes of a man whose head was bowed and whose body was trembling slightly.

No. Raindrops.

Yeah. That’s how it is.

I quietly looked up at the sky.

I couldn’t bring myself to look at Jin Wikyung like that, or at Lee Seowol silently mourning the death of her uncle, who had been her strongest support, or at the countless others in tears.

Whoosh.

The wind blew again.

The rain of flowers rose high, then fell around everyone as if to comfort them.

Yet beneath a sky clearer than ever, countless raindrops kept falling.

The Double Ninth Festival[3574] had passed, but the chrysanthemums hadn’t withered.

I knew that those who had left and those who remained were all here together.

And I knew that because of them, the road ahead had grown wider and brighter.

Ding.

A clear chime rang through the sky, mingling with the rain of flowers.

[3574] The Double Ninth Festival falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

Chapter 985

Leaving behind countless tears and a ceaseless rain of petals, tens of thousands of people—martial artists and ordinary folk alike—departed Eight Spring Gorge and returned to their places.

The memorial for the departed, and the belated Double Ninth Festival,[3575] had come to an end. But those who remained had to keep moving forward, toward tomorrow and the day after.

And when we returned to the Jin Family of Taiyuan, more than the few family members left behind in case of an emergency were waiting for us.

“My name is Huang. I serve, though inadequately, as a Hall Master of the Murim Alliance. I’ve come to deliver a message from the Alliance Leader.”

The Murim Alliance’s envoy introduced himself with impeccable courtesy, and everyone’s gaze turned toward the three of us brothers.

More precisely, toward Jin Wikyung.

“I see.”

His voice was calm, though the corners of his eyes were still red.

As if welcoming a guest he had long expected, Jin Wikyung calmly led the envoy inside.

“Before we talk, please come in and rest after your journey.”

“I’m deeply grateful for your consideration, Great Hero Jin.”

In that moment, an unmistakable emotion passed over the faces of the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s senior members and the Sect Leaders under its protection.

It wasn’t only because the envoy bowed so deeply, with genuine respect and reverence.

Great Hero.

Just two words, but they carried a special weight.

This wasn’t some nobody, one of those self-important fools forever puffing each other up. A renowned master of the martial world, entrusted with the important position of Hall Master in the Murim Alliance, had come as an envoy and addressed him that way.

Everything is changing.

I, too, felt the weight of it all over again.

Jin Wikyung was no longer the Lesser Family Head who had led a fading family in place of a father whose whereabouts were unknown. Nor was he merely a young martial artist.

[3575] The Double Ninth Festival, or *Jungyangjeol* in Korean, falls on the ninth day of the ninth lunar month.

He was the ruler of Shanxi Province, another Alliance Leader recognized by everyone in this land.

No, now he was…

“What are you thinking about so hard?”

At Hyuk Mujin’s sudden question in my ear, I shook my head.

“Nothing.”

“Doesn’t look like nothing.”

“Mujin.”

“Yes?”

“Want me to make your life a living hell?”

“…No. I was just going to tell you to hurry up and follow them. You were standing there by yourself.”

Hyuk Mujin was right.

Behind Jin Wikyung, who strode forward with confidence, came the Murim Alliance’s envoy, the family’s senior members, and the Sect Leaders under the Jin Family of Taiyuan, including Lee Seowol.

Their faces held a mixture of grief that had not yet faded and joy over something soon to become reality.

I watched them walk away in silence, then turned and headed in another direction.

“Huh? Where are you going?”

“No idea. Wherever I feel like.”

“What do you mean? Maybe someone else could miss it, but you of all people shouldn’t, Captain.”

“Doesn’t matter. I more or less know what they’re going to say anyway.”

“What?”

Hyuk Mujin tilted his head in confusion, then hurried after me. Hearing his footsteps behind me, I laughed softly.

At the same time, a memory came to me.

Eight Spring Gorge.

The narrow gorge that had swallowed so many lives, and the clear chime that rang out amid the rain of petals.

The holographic window that had announced yet another change.

Ding. Ding-ding.

SYSTEM

Since the world first began, nothing beneath the heavens has been eternal. The vast land and sea, the countless lives that dwell within them, and even the mighty power held by the rarest few are no exception.
No flower stays red for ten days (□□□□□), and no matter how great one's power, it does not last ten years (□□□□).
But when a tree's roots run deep, its branches grow thick (□□□□). When a spring runs deep, its waters flow far (□□□□). At last, it will become another world where many can dwell and find rest.

As the System had told me, the Jin Family of Taiyuan, once rotting like an ancient tree, had now become a forest.

It bore fruit at the ends of countless branches and created a lake as vast as the sea.

Though they might lack strength, the people I had seen and known among them had always been just and righteous.

Unlike those who had chosen the wrong path, seized by anger and greed.

SYSTEM

The Murong Family has fallen. They are no longer one of the Five Great Families.
At long last, the fame of the Jin Family of Taiyuan resounds throughout the world!
The fame and power of the Jin Family of Taiyuan have risen to that of a member of the Five Great Families!

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families.

Fifteen pillars that had upheld the martial world for hundreds of years.

And now, the Jin Family of Taiyuan had become one of those mighty pillars.

It wasn't simply because the Murim Alliance had appointed them, or because renowned masters from across the martial world had strongly urged it.

The whole world had accepted it. They had recognized the Jin Family's courage in standing against an army of tens of thousands.

They had recognized its resolve to protect not just Murim, but this land and its people.

And so, the provincial martial family that had once been slowly fading, its glory behind it, had come together and grown stronger than ever.

SYSTEM

The Title Scion of a Prestigious Family has been removed!
You have acquired a new Title: Direct Descendant of a Prestigious Family!
As your family's standing has risen, you have gained a tremendous amount of Fame!
Hidden Quest Might As Well Go All the Way to the Five Great Families successfully completed!
You have earned the very rare Achievement Dad, Where Are You? Glory and blessings to the three Jin Family brothers, who overcame countless hardships and trials through their own efforts!
Jin Wikyung and Jin Mukyung have been granted the effects of Amazing Natural Healing and various bonus buffs. It goes without saying that these effects will not be displayed to the individuals in question.
You have acquired 10 bonus stat points as an Achievement reward!
You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP!
Level Up!
You have gained a tremendous amount of Fame!
Your name and reputation have now reached beyond Murim and across the world. You are a feudal lord appointed by the Son of Heaven,[3576] a successor of the Fire King Jeok Cheongang, and a great martial artist in your own right.
Your footsteps have been inscribed in history.
Martial artists have begun to speak cautiously of the glorious Title granted to only ten martial artists beneath the vast sky and its three stars. They speak of the birth of a new young king.
Nothing has been decided yet. Just as the small flap of a butterfly's wings can bring a typhoon from afar, each of your choices, big or small, will gradually change this world.
But remember: time keeps moving.
May you have good fortune in Murim.

The System window had been far longer than usual. It had made the changes all the more palpable, but as always, it ended with a wish for good fortune in Murim.

For the first time in a long while, there was no follow-up Quest.

And yet that was the one thing that left me uneasy, even in the peace that had finally arrived.

[3576] "Son of Heaven" is a traditional title for the Chinese emperor.

What is this? I was sure something else would happen.

It had been a long time since I'd cared about getting stronger just for the sake of it.

In the Quests that came one after another, someone's death had been so inevitable that it might as well have been written into the bargain. And the burden I carried had grown just as heavy.

On top of that, a greater crisis than ever hung over all of Murim.

They're not the type to back off just because this plan failed.

It had always been like that.

Dark Heaven had carried out numerous schemes across Murim. Since murdering the Dharma King Hong Dao and stealing Shaolin Temple's divine artifact, the Green Jade Buddha Staff, they hadn't made a move anyone could call a success.

And yet, in Sichuan. In Hubei.

Then Nanman,[3577] the Imperial Palace, and now even here in Shanxi Province, they had brought one blood-soaked disaster after another.

The Murong Family's betrayal and the nomads' invasion were certainly huge events. But the forces Dark Heaven has revealed in the process are still far below what I expected.

Apart from the four Demon Lords and Demon Empress who were certainly key figures within Dark Heaven, more than half the enemies we had fought so far had been traitors and underlings.

In other words, it was as if they'd recruited their forces locally.

And they still haven't shown themselves. Why? And why keep up this string of costly battles that lead only to failure?

My steps had carried me onward without my noticing, but I stopped and frowned.

Then another memory came to me: part of a conversation with Murong Baek, Family Head of the Murong Family, who had met his end as the North Heaven Demon Lord.

"If that's what you all believe, fine. There's nothing wrong with continuing to hope."

"What?"

"Now that I'm in this situation, I find myself wondering why the Western Heaven Demon Lord, the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord failed. How did a plan prepared so carefully for so long fall apart in an instant?"

We never found out what those incomprehensible words meant.

The North Heaven Demon Lord died without explaining them.

But even after I drove the spearhead into his heart, and even now, days after all the fighting had ended, I remembered every detail of that moment clearly.

[3577] *Nanman* is a historical Chinese term for peoples and regions to the south.

His utterly calm voice and expression.

The North Heaven Demon Lord had been ready to die. He'd proved it moments later by drawing on even his innate qi.

He wasn't just saying it to shake my composure.

I know how honest a person can become when facing certain death.

At the end of a life they've chosen for themselves, people don't tell lies.

Then why? Why say that at all?

Of course, the North Heaven Demon Lord's tone and manner had given me some idea.

I just hadn't thought much about it because the possibility seemed so utterly unrealistic.

It was as if he thought this situation had been fated from the beginning—or as if he, too, had been used…

No matter how I looked at it, it made no sense.

After the fierce battle ended, I'd shared my thoughts with Jeok Cheongang. He'd answered more firmly than ever.

"Fate, my ass. And as much as those bastards deserve to die, you think masters that powerful grow on trees?"

"Yeah. Something does seem off, doesn't it?"

"Lord of Heaven. No matter how powerful that bastard is, he can't use people like them as disposable pawns. Not unless they've had their heads cracked open a couple of times by my Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist."

He was right.

There wasn't a madman anywhere in the world who would use Supreme Peak masters as pawns.

The Bow Saint hadn't agreed or disagreed. She'd only made an inscrutable face, but whatever she might have said probably wouldn't have differed much from Jeok Cheongang's answer.

No. Then why say it at all? And what's with this suspiciously quiet stretch of time?

I screwed up my face and thought it over.

Had he just spouted bullshit before he died? Or had his words carried some other meaning none of us, myself included, could guess?

As I clung to that endless chain of thoughts, a familiar voice suddenly broke in.

"No wonder you never came, even after I waited all that time. So this is where you were."

Jeok Cheongang.

His expression was heavier than ever. His voice was low and subdued as he continued.

"Come with me. There's someone who wants to see you."

Chapter 986

Truth be told, I'd had some idea from the start.

Jeok Cheongang's expression and tone were nothing like usual. Grief lay beneath his low, subdued voice—something the giant known as the Fire King rarely let anyone see.

But…

As always, a bad feeling never misses.

"You've arrived."

The first person to greet us was the Medicine King Hall Master, who had been standing guard at the door.

As he picked up his bundle and prepared to leave, Jeok Cheongang spoke quietly.

"As I asked, please don't tell anyone."

"…"

"Thank you. You're an excellent physician."

The Medicine King Hall Master bowed his head slightly without a word and left. Only then could we face the man waiting inside.

"Oh, you brought him sooner than I expected. That old man's legs are so short, I figured it'd take another seven days and nights."

Another giant had regained consciousness after several days.

I watched the Thunderbolt Saber King laugh heartily at his own joke. Only when Jeok Cheongang nudged my shoulder did I belatedly clasp my hands in a salute, showing him all the respect I could.

"I am Jin Taekyung, a humble junior of Murim. It's an honor to meet you, Great Hero Peng."

"Enough. Too much humility can be its own poison. If you're a humble junior, are all the other juniors in the world dead?"

The Thunderbolt Saber King smiled at me with satisfaction, then turned to Jeok Cheongang.

"Now that I've seen him, I'd say you were complaining for nothing. You kept telling me he ran wilder every day, like a brat with no respect for his elders."

"Friend, my ass. You've got a lot of nerve talking to someone so much older than you like that."

Jeok Cheongang tried to sound as gruff as ever, but he couldn't hide the heaviness in his eyes.

Whether the Thunderbolt Saber King noticed or not, he laughed even louder.

"Wahaha! What are you so sore about? We're both getting old."

"Don't you know the Three Bonds and Five Relationships[3578]? Never heard of respect for elders?"

"Would knowing them get someone to feed me? Or make my martial arts stronger?"

"Forget it. I'm the fool for trying to discuss this with an ignorant Peng."

"Admitting your own shortcomings. I like it. I was just getting tired of talking to a stinky old man, so this works out nicely. Don't you agree?"

At the Thunderbolt Saber King's offhand question, I nodded.

"Well, my Master *is* a little old."

"What did you say? Hahaha!"

A booming laugh rang out.

It didn't suit the Thunderbolt Saber King's pallid face. It was so loud it sounded forced.

No. It probably was forced.

What you could see with your eyes wasn't everything. I could feel it.

Even now, the qi within the Thunderbolt Saber King wavered precariously, like a glass vessel cracked all over.

Like a flame that could go out at any moment.

"I heard you wanted to see me."

At my somber words, the Thunderbolt Saber King seemed to realize I'd noticed his condition. He spoke with a smile still on his face.

"Perceptive, aren't you? You're worlds apart from the last time I saw you. The Fire King may not be good at much else, but he's raised his Disciple well."

"…"

"No need to look so miserable. For martial artists like us, life and death come with the territory."

He was right.

That was the life of a martial artist.

The Thunderbolt Saber King had spent his life making his way through a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords, past countless threats and schemes. Now he accepted what lay ahead with calm composure.

"I had a very long dream. In it, I looked back on my whole life. I even saw my friend Murong Baek as a young man again, for the first time in ages."

"Friend, my ass. That bastard deserved to die."

The Thunderbolt Saber King let out a quiet laugh at Jeok Cheongang's remark and continued.

[3578]The Three Bonds and Five Relationships are Confucian principles governing duties between people, including those between elders and juniors.

“That’s all in the past. Nothing to be done about it now. No use trying to gather up spilled water. In the end, we stopped Dark Heaven’s plot and saved more people. That’s enough for me.”

He was famous for a temper as fiery as Jeok Cheongang’s, yet he looked at me with eyes as still as a pond.

“When I first saw you at the Star-Array Grand Banquet, I had a feeling you’d accomplish great things before long. We could all tell you’d become a pillar of the world, protecting it alongside the Sword Saint’s Disciple.”

Of course, I’d been inexperienced back then.

I couldn’t stand shoulder to shoulder with so many powerful masters the way I could now. The monster known as the Blood Lord had crushed me.

“But no one expected you to grow so much, so quickly.”

The threats to my life had come one after another, each greater than the last, and I’d grown at a staggering pace because of them.

Fast enough to make even those who’d watched me most closely doubt their eyes.

“That’s why I asked for you right away. This is my last chance to put the little time and energy I have left to the best possible use.”

“…You mean…”

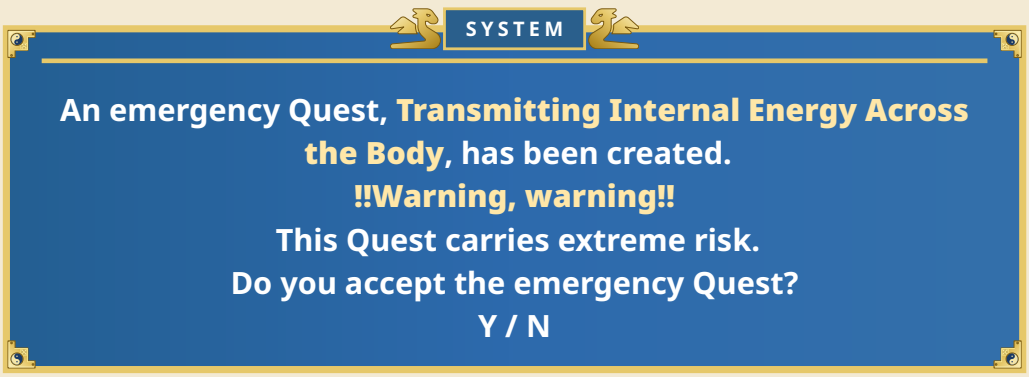
“They say an ordinary tiger leaves its hide behind when it dies. The great tiger of Hebei will be different.”

At the Thunderbolt Saber King’s faint smile, I finally understood why he’d asked to see me before his own flesh and blood. He had barely regained consciousness, and death was already at his door.

“Take it. Everything I have left.”

The moment his calm voice rang out—

Ding.



Through the holographic window that had appeared with the clear chime, I stared silently at the Thunderbolt Saber King’s smiling face.

Then, all at once, I spoke.

“Why… Why did you choose me?”

His answer came without the slightest hesitation.

“Because I believe in you.”

“…!”

“And I’m not the only one. The Dharma King believes in you. Your Master believes in you. Now the whole world believes in you.”

I could hardly breathe.

My heart tightened, and my blood seemed to surge through my veins.

Through it all, the Thunderbolt Saber King’s voice reached me clearly.

“This is all for the world, not for you. Do you need any other reason?”

“No.”

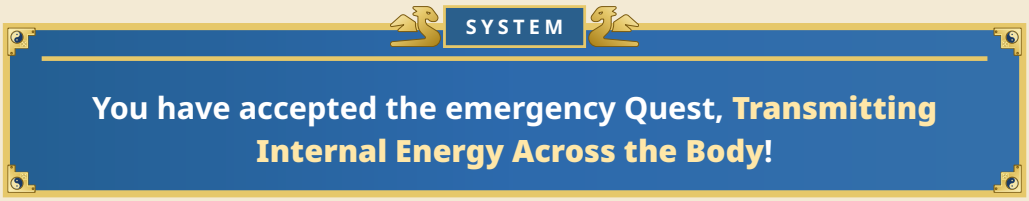
I took a small, steadying breath and continued.

“That’s reason enough.”

A smile crossed the Thunderbolt Saber King’s pallid face.

“Sit in the lotus position.”

Ding.



Internal energy was an intangible force that existed everywhere in the world.

Those who practiced martial arts accumulated it within their bodies. Through grueling training, they strengthened body and mind, hoping to step beyond human limits into the realm of the superhuman.

But not everyone wanted that kind of power.

The more energy they accumulated, the greater the backlash it could bring.

If someone tried to circulate their internal energy recklessly by following an incorrect formula, they were likely to end up crippled. And without enlightenment, many fell into a heart demon[3579] and became half-mad.

Even so, martial artists’ desire to reach ever higher realms rarely faded.

Theirs was a world ruled by the law of the jungle.

They devised all kinds of ways to grow stronger more safely and quickly. In the process, they discovered one astonishing method.

What if, instead of spending years accumulating internal energy, you received someone else’s in its entirety?

[3579] A *heart demon* is an inner obsession or mental disturbance that can obstruct spiritual or martial cultivation.

Inherit the power of an old master on the verge of death? Huh? Isn't that basically rock honey[3580]?

That was how Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body came into being in the distant past.

And from the moment it did, it became a taboo—something never to be attempted.

The reason was simple.

It looked sweet on the surface, but in reality, it was a double-edged sword.

No, even calling it that was laughable. Failures overwhelmingly outnumbered successes.

"M-Master!"

"No!"

People died. And died. And died again.

Even those lucky enough to survive often ended up crippled, their qi and blood tangled within them, or could never regain their former martial prowess. The attempts cost the world Supreme Peak masters who had dominated their eras, along with gifted young prodigies.

So when the Thunderbolt Saber King told Jin Taekyung he intended to transmit his internal energy to him, Jeok Cheongang could only ask in disbelief:

"Have you gone mad?"

"Not at all."

"No, you're definitely mad. Normally, you'd be flying into a rage by now."

"I've only been awake for half a shichen[3581], but my mind is unbelievably clear. I can't remember ever being this sharp in my life."

"Well, that's a hell of a thing to celebrate. Does that mean you can finally finish the Thousand Character Classic?"

"Cut the nonsense. You know this isn't simply madness."

In truth, the Thunderbolt Saber King was right.

Jeok Cheongang had answered that way only on reflex. In his heart, he was already weighing the chances that this insane undertaking could succeed.

"I hate to admit it, but that precious Disciple of yours could withstand Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body. He and that child Cheongpung were both born with the good fortune of a Heavenly Martial Physique, weren't they?"

"…The Heavenly Martial Physique."

"If that were all, I wouldn't be having this conversation with you. He has the Muscles and Bones Heaven granted him, as well as enough potential and insight as a martial artist."

[3580] *Seokcheong*, or rock honey, is wild honey gathered from bees nesting in rock crevices. In martial arts fiction, it is often imagined as a potent tonic.

[3581] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

A few months earlier, Jeok Cheongang would never have accepted a proposal that put his Disciple's life at risk, no matter how strongly anyone pressed him.

Not even from the Thunderbolt Saber King, who now stood at death's door after decades in which their rivalry had grown into a grudging affection.

But Jeok Cheongang had since heard the truth from Jin Taekyung himself.

There's a chance. No, he has what it takes.

A transfer of internal energy between two Supreme Peak masters who had reached their realms. There was no precedent for it in the long history of Murim.

And Jin Taekyung, whose superhuman body could only be described as a Heavenly Martial Physique, possessed one more strange power.

The Prison of Karma.

A divine strength that could purify his body and even heal injuries.

With that power, he had a chance as long as he remained alive.

Besides…

He's already succeeded at Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body once.

Jeok Cheongang had heard about it only later: Jin Taekyung had received the internal energy of the Heavenly Power Demon, a great fiend of the Demonic Cult imprisoned in the Sichuan Tang Clan's underground prison, and gone on to defeat the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

When Jeok Cheongang first heard, the knowledge that his Disciple had nearly died had almost made his heart burst. But the differences between then and now were clear.

The desperate circumstances were different. So was the martial prowess Jin Taekyung had since achieved.

He can do it. No…

He *will* do it.

He had to.

Jeok Cheongang steadied his wavering heart with firm resolve and watched the two men, joined through the Great Palace acupoint, his gaze deep and subdued.

Whoosh.

Internal energy beyond anything ever seen surged out in every direction.

Chapter 987

I still remember every moment of the day I first circulated my qi.

The qi-sea acupoint.

The energy I first encountered inside my body, in the place also known as the lower dantian, was pitiful.

Its name meant “sea of qi,” which felt almost laughable. In that cramped vessel, more like a little stream than a sea, only a handful of murky energy rippled.

That was right.

It had definitely been that way.

But…

Now it was different.

Ding.

SYSTEM

An emergency Quest, Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body, has begun.
Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body carries extreme risks. If anything goes wrong while internal energy is being transferred and absorbed, it may lead to qi deviation or death.

As the System’s notification gradually faded into the distance, my consciousness sank deep into my body.

When my eyes opened within that world, an endless ocean stretched before me.

Roooooar.

It stretched beyond sight. And it was hot.

Instead of clear blue waves, waves of fire surged without end.

An ocean of flame, vast beyond measure.

At its center, a gigantic fire dragon lay coiled atop a reef as black as pitch.

That’s…

I knew instinctively the moment I saw it.

In this place, filled with nothing but flames and heat, the reef where the fire dragon had made its home stood out as something especially alien.

The energy I received from the Heavenly Power Demon.

How could I forget?

The Heavenly Power Demon, once a great fiend of the Demonic Cult who had shaken the whole world, had passed his internal energy to me and asked me to defeat the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

Decades of imprisonment and torture had worn him down, leaving him with far less internal energy than his old reputation suggested. Perhaps that was why Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body had succeeded without killing me.

Put too much power into a vessel, and you break it.

The Heavenly Power Demon's energy had remained inside me ever since.

That energy served as the nest of the fire dragon, the very embodiment of Scorching Yang Qi born of the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts.

The two had coexisted well enough. They had even sustained each other. But now I instinctively understood something.

If I wanted to climb higher, I had to bring this strange relationship between two energies with different roots to an end.

Wake up.

The world around me responded to my focused will.

An unseen vibration swept across the ocean of flames and reached the fire dragon sleeping peacefully atop the reef.

Rumble.

Its massive body trembled. At last, its eyelids lifted, revealing blue-white eyes fixed directly on me.

The vertically slit eyes of a vicious beast.

But the emotion within them wasn't anger at being woken. It was obedience to its master.

Of course.

The fire dragon and the reef were both, in the end, part of this ocean.

And the master of this vast world deep inside my body was none other than me.

So, the instant our eyes met, that tremendous concentration of Scorching Yang Qi joined with my consciousness.

Whoosh!

Warmth and consciousness mingled.

My vision turned blue-white. One with the fire dragon, I flung out both arms without hesitation.

No—I spread wings as vast as my body and took flight.

Boom!

The reef shook as though an earthquake had struck. With a shockwave, I shot into the air and drew a deep breath high above it.

Hummm.

The energy, compressed layer upon layer, screamed.

Appalling heat surged from deep inside my body and raced up to my throat. If it hadn't been mine, it would have reduced me to ash long ago.

Now.

There was no hesitation. With the breath I finally released, pale blue flames burst forth and wrapped around the reef.

Before that hellfire, powerful enough to destroy the world, the pitch-black reef began to lose its shape and melt.

Then it was swept up by the waves of fire surging all around, rising high into the air. Having just breathed out a torrent of hellfire, I opened my mouth toward it.

Whooosh.

The moment I swallowed the dark-red liquid into which the reef had melted—

Gasp…!

My breath caught. It felt as though invisible blades were savagely carving through my insides.

Sharp pain assailed my mind before I could take any satisfaction in having quenched my thirst.

But I clenched my teeth.

I steadied my wavering mind and used all my strength to swallow back the energy surging up my throat.

So it could never regain its original form.

So it could dissolve into me anew.

My endurance and that choice were soon rewarded.

Rumble.

I could feel it.

Power swelling inside me.

The reef—or rather, the Heavenly Power Demon's energy—hadn't vanished.

I had absorbed it. In another sense, we had found a new way to coexist.

Unlike before, when it had been imperfect, now it had melted together into one. A perfect coexistence.

And with that astonishing change, something else began.

Rrrrrumble!

The world, red with flame, flashed.

A massive bolt of lightning split open the closed sky and pierced the ocean of flames.

Ah.

Before I could fully feel the change in my power, a genuine exclamation escaped me.

Yes.

It was a thunderbolt in the truest sense of the word.

The end of a long and fierce life.

It was the symbol of a giant standing at death's door—and the final legacy he meant to leave in this world through me.

As that massive bolt of lightning finally entered deep into my body through the Great Palace Acupoint, I moved toward it as if entranced.

I followed it upward and upward, along the current joining sea to sky.

Whooosh!

I couldn't hear it. And yet I seemed to hear it.

The sound of the fierce wind.

Everything I felt through the fire dragon's massive body, which had long since come to feel like my own.

My consciousness raced into the depths, perceiving everything as reality. I had risen so high that the ocean was no longer visible, and at last I saw it.

A gigantic mountain rising as though it would pierce the sky.

I already knew what it was.

The Middle Dantian.

The mountain known as the Jade Hall Acupoint glittered like a jewel, just as its name suggested.

All but one part of it: the highest peak.

Why? How come?

The question had barely surfaced before I found the answer.

It means I'm still not ready.

It had been quite some time since I opened my Middle Dantian, but even my incredible pace of growth had its limits.

That peak belonged to the realm of enlightenment.

A realm only those with heaven-given talent, blood-soaked effort, and long years behind them could enter.

Even after growing stronger at a dazzling pace, I couldn't easily reach that height.

But…

If not now, when will I ever get another chance to try?

I'd had countless strokes of good fortune, but heavenly fortune never came easily.

And an opportunity created by someone prepared to die was one I would never see again.

Let's go.

Maybe my hesitation had vanished the moment all this began. Maybe the System's warning had lost its meaning then, too.

I'd already swallowed the Heavenly Power Demon's energy. I already knew what I had to do.

Crackle. Crackle-crackle!

The bolt of lightning kept shining, refusing to fade.

I leaped into its massive pillar of light.

Rooooar!

Everything turned white. Agony beyond anything I'd felt while absorbing the Heavenly Power Demon's energy wrung every muscle in my body and burned away my consciousness.

Gyaaaah!

I didn't know where I was.

I couldn't tell whether the desperate scream ringing in my mind was mine or the fire dragon's.

As my consciousness grew hazy, all I heard was someone's thunderous shout.

"Hah!"

The instant Jeok Cheongang's unmistakable shout rang out—

"…!"

My rapidly sinking consciousness snapped awake.

Strength returned to my limp body. Memories of reality came back to me.

Who I was. Where I was.

And…

What I had to do for everyone who had believed in me, a callow, inadequate brat.

Endure. And keep enduring.

With all my strength, I bore the pain that kept tearing through my body.

I mustered the Scorching Yang Qi within the fire dragon and the Heavenly Power Demon's energy I'd just absorbed. Drawing on every last scrap of strength, I bit into the pillar of lightning.

Crunch. Crunch.

Lightning flashed before my eyes. It held everything that giant had been, and now it was numbing my mind beyond the point of pain.

Luckily for me.

Fuck, it's not like I've never shit blood before.

At some point, I started laughing like a madman.

I bit into the lightning, swallowed it, and kept going without pause, even as I nearly blacked out from the pain I'd known was coming.

Until the distant flash that had filled my vision slowly dimmed.

Until at last it vanished completely, as though it had never existed.

Rumble.

Suddenly, through my hazy consciousness, I realized:

The massive bolt of lightning that had connected my Middle and Lower Dantians was gone.

The thunder I could hear from somewhere was ringing out inside me.

I did it…

The moment I understood that Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body had succeeded—

Ding. Ding. Ding-ding-ding!

Clear chimes began ringing without pause, somewhere far off in my consciousness.

But the sound hadn’t come from the ocean of the Lower Dantian, now far in the distance, or from the peak of the Middle Dantian, finally glowing like a brilliant jewel.

I raised my head and saw it.

Clouds beyond the mountain peak’s reach.

Another world hidden behind them.

The upper dantian.

I was thirsty. With my goal achieved, my consciousness, which had nearly unraveled to a thread, began to grow clearer.

It was thirst. Longing.

More, more, more…!

I wanted to grow stronger. I wanted to go farther.

I wanted to break through those white clouds, soar above them, and look down on everything.

But I had to force down that burning thirst and longing.

I was already at my limit.

Any more would be greed.

I knew what this momentary impulse would bring.

Next time. I swear.

With that vow, I looked down over the mountain and ocean that had become wholly mine.

For the first time, I faced the essence within the three currents of energy, now united, and the vast power they formed.

No—I became one with it.

Ah. Ahhh.

I shuddered and groaned.

I floundered in my fading consciousness.

Enveloped in a dazzling radiance where three lights mingled, I forgot everything around me.

No-self.

As I sank into that endless swamp of consciousness, I heard a voice like a hallucination.

“Good judgment. Just like back then.”

The voice felt unfamiliar, yet somehow familiar, as though I’d heard it before.

Then the thread of my consciousness snapped.

Chapter 988

At some point, the Thunderbolt Saber King, Peng Cheolhu, had begun to laugh without a sound.

Even as the several sixty-year cycles' worth of internal energy he'd accumulated, along with every ounce of strength in his body, melted away and vanished, the clear smile at the corners of his wrinkled mouth remained.

Just like the brilliant halo of light still brightening his view in this very moment.

Whoooosh.

The wind howled.

An energy unlike anything seen before swelled within it. Three lights, each a different color, drew together and mingled without pause.

And at last, they changed.

Whoosh!

The air turned searing hot. Through it, the Thunderbolt Saber King saw three radiant flower buds bloom.

No—what he saw was a young man seated cross-legged, slowly rising into the air.

Yes. I suppose so.

He was witnessing Three Flowers Gather at the Crown, the realm every martial artist in Murim dreamed of reaching. But he wasn't surprised.

He'd walked this path himself once. And it was someone else's present.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

Heir to the Fire Gate Clan and successor to the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

The Thunderbolt Saber King knew. He believed it, too.

For that callow brat, who'd only passed twenty two years ago, the realm of Three Flowers Gather at the Crown was nothing more than a step on the way to a greater height.

Even now, Jin Taekyung was moving toward the next step.

Before long, the Thunderbolt Saber King saw that belief become reality.

Fwoosh.

The three flower buds suddenly caught fire.

After a fierce struggle, the Extreme Yang flames swallowed the pitch-black energy. The moment five rings formed, the Thunderbolt Saber King gave a quiet laugh.

Beyond Three Flowers Gather at the Crown… Five Qi Returning to Origin.

Jin Taekyung probably didn't know exactly what those five rings meant.

But the Thunderbolt Saber King did.

No, every martial artist under Heaven knew. To set foot in the realm of Five Qi Returning to Origin was to meet the bare minimum qualification for being called a king across the vast Nine Provinces.

But the transformation didn't end there.

Crackle!

Flame and lightning intertwined.

The struggle between the hellfire that had swallowed the darkness and the thunderbolt was fierce, desperate enough to leave Jin Taekyung trembling with pain as he floated in the air.

A tremendous reverberation burst from his body and spread in every direction, far beyond the pavilion.

"Hah!"

At Jeok Cheongang's sudden shout, Jin Taekyung's violent trembling slowly began to subside.

His face, contorted like a fiend's by the terrible pain, took on a new expression.

Will.

It was Will: a fierce resolve to break rather than yield, to get past this wall and reach higher still.

When the Thunderbolt Saber King felt Jin Taekyung's Will, he was finally certain.

I made the right choice.

A smile brighter than any before spread across his face.

He watched the internal energy he'd spent a lifetime accumulating—those long years, and the little life he had left—melt into the flames. Then he spoke, making his voice gruff despite everything he felt.

"Damn it. I've done nothing but good things for the Fire Gate Clan before I go."

The old master gazed at his Disciple, enveloped in the energy that had finally become one amid the distant blaze of light, and answered.

"If you're so sore about it, you should've had more kids. If you'd tried a little harder, maybe the Peng Family would've had a brat like him."

"Would you listen to this senile old man? You took a monster for a Disciple by pure luck, and now you're saying whatever you please."

"That's right. I was lucky."

"Damn it. Don't admit it!"

"Why not?"

"Because if you admit it that easily, I've got nothing to say."

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, and the Thunderbolt Saber King, Peng Cheolhu, looked at each other and chuckled.

"Remember that time?"

"What time?"

“Just after the Great Faction War ended, I think. When we all got together for a drink to celebrate.”

“Oh, the day you mouthed off to this old man and got a bloody nose?”

The Thunderbolt Saber King frowned.

“Get it straight. We were evenly matched until then.”

“We were. For about thirty exchanges. Then you got beaten. I was clearly a cut above.”

“…Childish to the very end. There’s a reason they say people never change.”

“If a man changes, it means he’s about to die. Anyway, it was my complete victory.”

“You insufferable old bastard. Did you eat all those years through your asshole?”

Fifty years ago, they would surely have been throwing punches at each other by now.

Instead, the two old men kept smiling.

One was doing his best to hide the bitterness rising from deep within him. The other had accepted both the years long gone and the death drawing near.

Jeok Cheongang looked at Peng Cheolhu, whose hair had turned completely white, and made a show of scowling.

“You ill-mannered brat. I told you, if you’re going to treat me like an old man, you ought to count our years properly and show me the respect I’m due.”

“Damn it. The age thing again.”

“I’ve told you hundreds of times. Is your skull made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron? Is that why you can’t remember?”

“Enough of what I don’t want to hear. Fine, I understand. I’ll show you respect, all right?”

“Peng Family bastards, honestly… What did you just say?”

Jeok Cheongang stopped mid-sentence. At his startled expression, the Thunderbolt Saber King let out a hearty laugh.

“What’s the matter? Have you gotten so old you’ve gone deaf, Jeok hyung[3582]?”

“…!”

“Tsk, tsk. What’s the point of looking young again? All those years, and nothing to show for them.”

Jeok Cheongang stared at him in silence as he clicked his tongue loudly enough to be heard. Then, all at once, he laughed aloud.

“What are you laughing at?”

“Nothing. I just lived long enough to see this day. Have you got a problem with that?”

[3582] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"I always have a problem with something. But can a younger brother talk back to his hyung[3583]?"

Younger brother.

Why did those two simple words stir something in Jeok Cheongang's chest? He forced his fading smile back onto his lips.

"You've finally come to your senses. I wondered how long you'd keep digging in your heels."

"Now, now. Is that any way to speak to your younger brother? It seems Jeok hyung[3584] still hasn't come to his senses."

"Then shall I call you Peng, my younger brother, from now on?"

This time, the Thunderbolt Saber King laughed aloud. His face, covered in fine wrinkles and age spots after he'd given away everything he had, creased deeply.

"No. Better not. Hearing you say that makes me itch right down to my guts."

"You damnable bastard. What do I have to do to satisfy you?"

"That's much better. You've finally turned back into the Fire King Jeok Cheongang I know."

At last, the Thunderbolt Saber King smiled in satisfaction. When he spoke again, his voice was gentle.

"Jeok hyung[3585]."

Jeok Cheongang didn't answer.

No—he couldn't.

The sudden change in the Thunderbolt Saber King's tone and expression, the voice that now sounded unmistakably like an old man's—something about it lodged in Jeok Cheongang's throat and left him speechless.

The Thunderbolt Saber King looked at him as if he understood and went on.

"You, at least… don't change, Jeok hyung[3586]."

"…!"

"Stay in Murim as you are, just as you always have."

So many years had passed.

The sun and moon kept changing places. The mountains and rivers changed their clothes in turn, and those born into this world with vigorous cries returned to the soil.

Yet some had not changed.

[3583] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

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[3586] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Their bodies had aged with the years, but their hearts remained steadfast.

“Looking back, I’ve been very lucky.”

Years flashed like meteors through the Thunderbolt Saber King’s fading eyes.

He had been born into the Hebei Peng Family, a power that commanded its region, and spent a childhood wanting for nothing.

In his youth, his name had spread beyond the northern lands and across the world.

And then—

“Even in that terrible war, I had friends I could fight back to back with.”

“…Yes. You did. You still do.”

Jeok Cheongang’s voice was dry. He quietly bit his lip. He was no longer smiling.

“Jeok hyung[3587].”

“Go on. I’m listening.”

“Do you remember what I used to say all the time?”

Jeok Cheongang nodded without hesitation.

“That a man should meet his death proudly on the battlefield.”

“You remembered.”

“How could I forget? You said it several times a day.”

“I did. And every time, you threatened to rip my mouth open.”

The Thunderbolt Saber King laughed happily at the old memory. But instead of the thunderous laughter that had once boomed from him, only a faint breath came out.

“I take it back. Now that I’ve come this far… this kind of death isn’t so bad after all.”

His head kept drooping. He forced it up, straightened his bent back, and looked over Jeok Cheongang’s shoulder.

At the figure floating there, engulfed in deep light.

Crack. Creak.

The sound of flesh tearing came from Jin Taekyung’s body as fine tremors spread through it. The Thunderbolt Saber King watched with joy in his eyes as Jin Taekyung entered Bone Transformation—a process he himself had never experienced.

Supreme Peak.

He had climbed the summit and reached the utmost height: the highest place on earth, and the path closest to Heaven.

[3587] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

"Jeok hyung[3588]. Do you see him?"

At the Thunderbolt Saber King's voice, trembling with emotion, Jeok Cheongang turned to look at his Disciple.

"Yes. I see him. My one and only Disciple—and the successor who inherited everything you had."

"Is that so?"

Death had already dimmed the Thunderbolt Saber King's eyes. He could no longer see Jeok Cheongang's face or Jin Taekyung's form.

And yet, in the darkness slowly approaching, he saw a radiant halo of light that would not go out.

"Th-that child…"

He struggled for breath.

Clinging to his fading consciousness, he reached toward the light shining beyond the darkness.

Toward the future he had left behind. Toward hope.

Then he cast off everything pressing down on his body and lunged toward the light.

Toward a new mountain peak that didn't exist in this world, waiting for him.

Toward another Supreme Peak: death.

Tap.

His fingertips fell limply, touching nothing.

Jeok Cheongang quietly closed his eyes. A low voice slipped between his lips.

"Farewell, you Peng bastard."

He would save the words *younger brother* for the day they met again.

That was his last promise to the Thunderbolt Saber King—no, to Peng Cheolhu.

And as the Fire King Jeok Cheongang, rather than Jeok hyung[3589], he still had far too much left to do.

Whoosh.

Feeling the halo of light finally begin to fade, Jeok Cheongang opened his eyes.

[3588] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[3589] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

Chapter 989

The Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho, was having another day so busy he couldn't catch his breath.

Or, more accurately, he was supposed to be.

When he rose after less than two hours of sleep, he already had his day planned out in fifteen-minute increments.

But the moment he read the red missive brought by a Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent before sunrise, the Thousand-Faced Fox realized one thing:

Today would not go according to plan.

"Cancel the meeting already on the schedule. Instead, summon the Inner Hall's officers within fifteen minutes."

"I'll make sure every one of them is notified."

"What's the situation in the Outer Hall?"

"They're already on alert. The messenger eagles bound for each province are ready and waiting for your orders, Pavilion Master—"

"Send them out at once. I'll see the Alliance Leader in the meantime."

After giving several more orders, the Thousand-Faced Fox hurried toward his destination.

As always, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was waiting for him, seated cross-legged.

"It's early for bad news. You could've waited until sunrise, at least."

His voice and gaze were as clear as the water at a lakeshore.

Usually, the Number One Sword Under Heaven's composure made him seem utterly carefree. Faced with it now, the Thousand-Faced Fox spoke cautiously.

"Did you already… know?"

"I can't say I know. I just found it hard to sleep last night."

Mae Jonghak slowly opened his eyes and looked at the Thousand-Faced Fox.

Or, more precisely, at the red missive in his hand.

"So. Who is it this time?"

Mae Jonghak's voice had sunk low.

Many years had passed, and much had changed. But some things remained the same.

Red missives bearing tragic news were one of them.

During the Great Faction War, whenever an important figure died or heavy casualties were reported, they had written those missives with heavy hearts.

Just like the one in the Thousand-Faced Fox's hand now.

"Alliance Leader."

"It's all right. Tell me the name written in that red missive."

The Thousand-Faced Fox hesitated, then spoke somberly.

“The Thunderbolt Saber King, who was staying with the Jin Family of Taiyuan, has finally…”

“Enough. That will do.”

Mae Jonghak waved a hand, his expression bitter.

“So it came to this, after all.”

“I’m sorry to bring you such news.”

“You? No. If someone must be blamed, it should be me—the Alliance Leader.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox bowed his head without a word.

The two men had known each other for decades: first as promising young martial artists of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, then as comrades who had joined forces to weather the war.

For now, he needed to give Mae Jonghak time to receive the news as the dead man’s friend, not as the Alliance Leader. Fortunately, the silence did not last long.

“How did Senior Peng pass?”

“They say he was smiling until the end. He knew he had little time left, so he passed on everything he had through Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body.”

The astonishing news left out one crucial detail: to whom.

But Mae Jonghak didn’t need to ask. Before the Thousand-Faced Fox had finished speaking, a name had already come to mind.

“Jin Taekyung. It must have been that boy.”

“Yes. It was an extremely dangerous attempt, but I’m told the technique succeeded.”

Mae Jonghak nodded quietly.

Though he’d spent only a short time with Jin Taekyung, he’d had a vague sense that the transfer would succeed.

“That boy could certainly pull it off. There’s no telling how deep his abilities run.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox’s next report, however, drew a disbelieving laugh even from Mae Jonghak.

“Bone Transformation?”

The Heavenly Martial Physique was something one was born with. Bone Transformation, by contrast, completely rebuilt the body through immense internal energy and enlightenment.

Even a white-haired old man on the verge of death could regain his youth and make remarkable gains in martial arts through Bone Transformation.

And yet that fortune, coveted by all, had come to a young man around twenty.

Even the Thousand-Faced Fox, who had read the report with his own eyes, plainly struggled to believe it.

“Is this truly… possible?”

“You don’t seem convinced.”

“I doubt most people would be.”

“Why do you think it’s impossible?”

“In the entire thousand-year history of Murim, how many have experienced Bone Transformation? As far as I know, fewer than twenty.”

“You have a point. But there’s something you’re overlooking.”

“What is it?”

Mae Jonghak spread one hand instead of answering.

“Five.”

“What does that—”

“Of those fewer than twenty, five have appeared in this age alone.”

“…!”

“No—now there’ll be six.”

The Martial God and the Three Saints.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, and his Disciple, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

Mae Jonghak raised another finger as he named them, then continued calmly.

“Isn’t it strange? Only around twenty people have undergone Bone Transformation in the last thousand years, yet the orthodox Murim alone already has six.”

“That’s…”

“You’ve felt it yourself, I’m sure. You just can’t easily accept it out loud.”

Mae Jonghak uncrossed his legs and stood.

He looked so ordinary that the Thousand-Faced Fox might have passed him anywhere without a second glance. But the eyes meeting his were clear as glass.

“We live in a truly strange age. The boundaries of common sense collapsed long ago, and a vast, unimaginable shadow has fallen over the world.”

More than fifty years ago, two supreme figures had appeared in the same age: the Martial God and the Heavenly Demon.

And that was hardly all.

Dozens of Supreme Peak masters from the orthodox, unorthodox, and Demonic factions had gathered around them, and a battle had begun between superhumans wielding unprecedented power.

The Three Saints and the Ten Kings. Great fiends of the Demonic Cult and the unorthodox faction, with power enough to shake heaven and earth.

And…

“Now Dark Heaven has appeared, surpassing even the Demonic Cult of that era by far.”

Does the age make the people, or do the people make the age?

The question had inspired countless debates, but no one had found a clear answer. Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was no exception.

Yet deep down, he knew the age he lived in was more than a mere time of chaos.

He sensed something hidden behind the conflict between superhumans—whether they had been born of this chaotic age or were bringing it into being.

“Supernatural powers we cannot understand. Monsters in horrific forms. And at the center of it all, someone called the Lord of Heaven.”

His gaze deepened as he murmured, almost to himself.

“Sometimes I wonder if all of this is a scheme devised by someone beyond our imagining.”

Mae Jonghak suddenly turned to look out the window.

White snowflakes drifted slowly down, so thick they obscured the sunlight spreading from the distant east.

Snow in early autumn. A tremendous snowfall, at that.

In Henan’s warm climate, such a thing was not merely rare—it had been unheard of. Yet it had begun happening several months ago.

And not only in Henan. It was happening across the world.

The changes were not confined to the ground, either.

The sky that had always hung above them—the heavenly patterns whose change Dharma King Hong Dao had long ago foreseen—was changing rapidly.

“Can you make sense of any of this?”

At Mae Jonghak’s question, the Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho, bit his lip without a word.

Cold sweat had soaked his back.

“I—I can’t. I can’t even begin to guess what’s about to happen.”

His voice trembled.

Even a man who had served the Martial God at close quarters and fought the hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path led by the Heavenly Demon could not stay calm when he thought of what lay ahead.

It was as though…

Something beyond the bounds of the human world.

The words hovered on the tip of his tongue. The Thousand-Faced Fox could not bring himself to say them, so he swallowed them instead.

He couldn’t believe it.

No—he didn’t want to believe it.

Mae Jonghak watched the Thousand-Faced Fox’s agitation with clear eyes.

“Pavilion Master Song. May I say one thing to you as your superior and the Alliance Leader?”

"Please."

"Admit that you're afraid. Accept it."

"…!"

"Be more afraid than anyone else. Always be on guard against our enemies and distrust them. You and I have no choice. We're in positions where we have to."

The Thousand-Faced Fox understood the meaning behind Mae Jonghak's words at once.

"I'll take your words to heart, Alliance Leader."

"Thank you. You're a coolheaded, intelligent man. One of the most… no, not *the* most, but certainly among the ten most intelligent people I've known."

The Thousand-Faced Fox let out a dry chuckle.

"So there are quite a few ahead of me."

"I have to get the numbers right. Try not to be offended."

"I won't take that part to heart."

"Good news. You already have more than enough pressing matters on your mind."

"Of course. Then I'll take my leave."

Mae Jonghak smiled faintly but did not stop the Thousand-Faced Fox as he hurried away, moving as briskly as he had when he arrived.

Once he was alone, Mae Jonghak slowly read the red missive left behind. Then he murmured under his breath.

"So I'm saying goodbye to someone again."

Beyond their friendship, the Thunderbolt Saber King's death was a tremendous loss to the orthodox Murim as a whole.

Half of the Ten Kings had fallen over the long years. Of the five who remained, another was gone.

Perhaps the trace left by that giant's final step could ease the grief of his passing, if only a little.

"The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung."

Mae Jonghak quietly spoke the name that had lingered in his mind.

A great star, the Thunderbolt Saber King, had fallen, and a new star had risen to fill the void.

No—he had already been shining brightly before this.

As if to prove his title, Divine Dragon.

Before long, two dragons will finally ascend to the heavens.

Mae Jonghak did not doubt it for a moment.

Jin Taekyung, now a giant of Murim, and the last successor Mae Jonghak had raised like his own grandson would stand at the center of this strange age.

Thinking of Cheongpung, who must by now have finally heard the news from Shanxi Province even where he was so far away, Mae Jonghak poured internal energy into the missive in his hand.

Fwoosh. Crackle.

The flames of Samadhi True Fire tinted Mae Jonghak's clear eyes red.

Chapter 990

The Thunderbolt Saber King, Peng Cheolhu.

News that the Grand Family Head of the Hebei Peng Family—yet another giant born of the Great Faction War—had fallen spread like a raging wildfire.

“I thought he, at least, would hold firm… And yet it’s come to this.”

“Even so, who could’ve imagined the Saber King would meet such a pointless end?”

“Pointless? Don’t ever say that in front of me again. Great Hero Peng held fast to his chivalrous spirit until the very end.”

“Enough. You think he said that because he didn’t know? He’s just heartbroken.”

“I know. Damn it, I know.”

The martial artists who received the unexpected and tragic news could not hide their grief.

To them, the title of one of the Ten Kings carried a meaning unlike any other.

Yet Hong Dao, the Dharma King who had earned everyone’s respect, was gone.

So was Tang Taesang, the Poison King who had struck fear into countless members of the Demonic Cult.

And now even the Thunderbolt Saber King—the man who, apart from the overwhelming presence of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, had been all but the foremost of the Ten Kings—had met his death.

None of them had died of old age or illness.

“Don’t forget. They died honorably, fighting for what was right. Avenge them—that duty falls to us now.”

The old masters who had symbolized the orthodox Murim and stood for chivalry were dying one after another.

The martial artists of Murim layered anger over their grief.

To avenge those they had lost.

To defeat the new enemy, which had emerged for the first time since the Demonic Cult and revealed a power more threatening than ever.

“Who will stand against Dark Heaven!”

“Take up your swords! For the Nine Provinces, for justice and chivalry—rise up and fight those fiends!”

Rousing shouts rang out on streets everywhere. They had become an everyday occurrence.

Learning from the Murong Family’s example, Sect Leaders and Family Heads of various factions met often and put old grudges behind them. Young people, their blood burning with fervor, swung weapons they had never so much as bloodied until their palms split.

Even a stone leaves a mark when it moves. How much greater the mark left by a mountain?

The bloody battle fought across a narrow gorge in Shanxi Province—the incident that came to be known as the Eight Heavens Blood Calamity—and the death of the Thunderbolt Saber King had been the final sparks.

Dark Heaven had stirred up bloodshed across the land without ever revealing its full strength. Those who feared it now understood, as did the martial artists caught between the orthodox and unorthodox factions who had once been reluctant to oppose it.

The razor-sharp blade in Dark Heaven's hand was aimed not only at the orthodox Murim, but at the entire world.

And the repercussions had long since spread far beyond Murim's borders.

"So, who are you, and where are you from?"

"I'm Jang-pal, from Jeong Family Village."

"Jang-pal? If you're from Jeong Family Village, why is your surname Jang?"

"Pardon?"

"Why Jang-pal?"

"Oh, well…"

"Well, what?"

"My father's from somewhere else."

"Somewhere else, huh? So he married into the family and settled in Jeong Family Village."

"Yes, yes. That's right."

"How old are you?"

"I turned twenty this year."

The low-ranking official assigned to recruit soldiers looked the applicant up and down. Young man? The fellow standing before him ought to have been called a boy.

"Twenty?"

"Yes, sir!"

"I see. Then what is your mother's full name?"

"What?"

"The more we talk, the more familiar you look. I might know your family. If I do, I could send you somewhere you'd have a good chance to earn military merit."

At the official's coaxing tone, the boy's eyes lit up.

"Y-you really mean it?"

"Of course. So, what's your mother's name?"

The boy hesitated, but not for long.

He might not have his family's permission, but his sense of chivalry and his dreams of making his mark on the world had never burned brighter.

If his parents were acquainted with the official in front of him, this was the perfect chance to be posted to a good battlefield, earn brilliant merit, and become a young general.

Me too. I'll be like him one day.

He had already made up his mind.

Thinking of the idol he had never once seen in person, the boy found his courage. He gripped the bamboo spear he had clumsily whittled himself and opened his mouth.

"Th-the second daughter of the Oh family from the house by the persimmon tree. She said people nearby would know her…"

"Go home."

"What?"

"Your father's a Jeong, your mother's an Oh, so why do you live in Jeong Family Village?"

"…!"

"What, still got something to say?"

The official glared at him as though he already knew everything. The boy stiffened, then barely managed to force out a reply.

"Actually, my whole family came from somewhere else…"

"What are you waiting for? Drag this brat out!"

"Gah, sir! No! You can't! You'll really regret turning me away!"

The boy's eyes widened with fierce determination. Deeply moved by the sight, the official gave an order to the guards holding him by both arms.

"Give him three swats on the rear and toss him out. Twenty, my ass. You little brat—first you lie, and then you glare at an adult?"

"Siiir!"

His desperate cries changed nothing.

Ever since the Emperor's proclamation had spread throughout the land, government offices in every province had been packed with people who couldn't contain their dreams of making a name for themselves or the hot blood in their veins.

The official was in danger of dying from overwork before Dark Heaven ever got to him. He'd had his fill of boys lying about their age to enlist.

"Give him two more!"

"Nooo!"

"Yes!"

In the end, the guards gave the boy a sound kick to the rear and drove him out. The applicants, whose line stretched all the way outside the government office, watched him go and murmured among themselves.

“He looks younger than my little brother.”

“Still, the kid’s got spirit. Shame his head’s a complete rock.”

“But where did he say he was from again?”

“Doesn’t matter. He obviously made it up.”

“No, I still need to know.”

“Why are you so hung up on it?”

“I made mine up too.”

“…”

“I can’t have the place name overlapping by accident. They’ll catch me, and I’ll end up like him.”

“…How old are you, by the way?”

“Sixteen.”

“Cut the crap. You’ve got the face of a grizzled veteran.”

“Thank you, hyung[3590]. Looks like I’ll get through just fine. And please keep this a secret.”

“…Wait, you weren’t joking?”

While everyone else was still reeling, the applicant with the weathered face called to the boy as he staggered to his feet.

“How old are you?”

The boy, staring blankly at the government office, answered.

“Sixteen.”

“Same as me. Since we’ve met, let’s drop the formalities.”

“Not even a stray dog would believe that. I’m in a lousy enough mood already.”

“I’m serious.”

“I’m not falling for… it, sir.”

“Anyway, where’d you get that spear?”

The boy fidgeted before answering.

“I whittled it myself…”

“Don’t people our age usually use swords? Like me.”

The boy’s face twisted at once.

“Who says that? The spear is the king of all weapons.”

“There, you’re talking to me normally now. And I never said swords were the best. I just said most people use them.”

[3590] *Hyung* is a Korean term a male speaker uses to address an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

“Oh.”

“Seeing you get worked up over weapons tells me one thing. You came here because you want to be like ‘that person,‘ didn’t you?”

The boy hesitated, then answered in a much softer voice.

“Show him some respect.”

“What?”

“Don’t call him ‘that person.‘ Speak of him with respect.”

His dejected look had vanished.

As if nothing had happened, he seemed to have forgotten he’d just been thrown out of the government office. His eyes brightened as he continued.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. I’m going to be like him. I will!”

Everyone had a goal they wanted to reach.

For the boy, Jin Taekyung was that goal.

A young hero of the martial world, watched by the entire land, and a noble marquis personally appointed by the Son of Heaven.

He admired him. Respected him.

When he’d strode here so confidently, he’d been full of ambition. Before long, he’d thought, he would stand shoulder to shoulder with Jin Taekyung.

Reality, of course, had kicked him in the rear and thrown him out.

“Damn it.”

The boy lowered his head gloomily.

Then a strange voice suddenly rang out from somewhere.

“Wow! That’s so cool!”

The boy looked up and blinked at the speaker. Everyone waiting outside the government office did the same.

Who’s that?

When did he show up? I don’t think he was here a moment ago.

Huh. Or was he?

Now that I think about it, maybe he was here the whole time…

They exchanged bewildered glances. But before anyone could make sense of it, the young man who had suddenly appeared before them was smiling brightly at the boy.

“My grandpa told me— No, someone told me it’s good to have a goal you want to achieve!”

“Y-yes?”

The boy stared at the young man, bewildered.

Perhaps it was the long robe caked in dust. The young man looked more than ordinary—he looked downright shabby.

Maybe that was why the shock of his sudden appearance and his attempt to strike up a conversation soon gave way to an inexplicable sense of familiarity. The boy felt it, and so did everyone else.

It was like… like…

Right.

That one slow older guy every neighborhood seems to have.

For once, everyone was thinking the same thing. How could they not?

Just look at that spotless, pure-white smile.

There wasn't a speck of malice in his eyes. They were clearer than a stream, and then he grabbed the boy's hand and shook it over and over—the way a little kid might.

"That's so cool! You're determined to become like the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon. That's amazing!"

With both hands trapped in the young man's grip, the wide-eyed boy finally came back to his senses when his shoulders began to ache.

"P-please let go."

"Oh, sorry. I got excited. Did I hurt you?"

You couldn't spit in a smiling face. Seeing how genuinely worried the young man looked, the boy couldn't bring himself to complain.

"…No, I'm fine. But who exactly are you?"

"Just a passing hero who wants to save the world, like you, Young Hero!"

He puffed out his chest and declared it proudly. The boy and everyone else reached the same conclusion.

Yep. Definitely slow.

And, proving their suspicions, the young man kept babbling about whatever came to mind, oblivious to the strange atmosphere.

"But, Young Hero, if you want to become like the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, why come to the government office? Wouldn't it be better to go straight to the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

"Oh, it's just so far away. I've never been more than a hundred li[3591] from home in my life. How could I…?"

"It's far, but not *that* far."

"Not that far? From here in Qinghai to Shanxi?"

"It goes by faster than you'd think. As long as you keep running hard and don't give up."

Snickers broke out around them.

[3591] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi). A hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi); ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

From Qinghai Province to Shanxi Province was nearly ten thousand li[3592], give or take a little exaggeration.

Even old peddlers who roamed the land with a few packs on their backs, and even the major Escort Bureaus, avoided taking on journeys that long whenever possible.

The trip would be grueling and mind-numbingly dull.

If even people who made their living on the road felt that way, what about those who lived in Qinghai, on the far western edge of the realm?

It was the sort of nonsense only a fool would say.

But to a boy whose own impossible dream had drawn laughter, the young man's words sounded different.

"Just keep at it and don't give up?"

"Right! And even if the Jin Family of Taiyuan is too far away, there are other options. For example…"

"Do you mean the Kunlun Sect?"

"Oh, you know about it?"

"Yes. I'm from around here, of course I do. And I know I'm too old to join the Kunlun Sect."

The boy sighed deeply before going on.

"But I don't want to join the Black Dragon Demon Gate. I know it belongs to the Murim Alliance, but its roots are still in the unorthodox faction. There are some unpleasant rumors about it, too."

"Hmm. What about the other sects…?"

"The details are different, but it's much the same with them. I'd rather join the military, learn strategy, and someday become a general leading an army. That might bring me a little closer to his fame."

After pouring all that out, the boy gave a self-mocking laugh.

What was the point of telling a complete stranger—one who seemed none too bright—all this?

"I should go. Maybe I'll see you again sometime."

"Hey, wait."

The boy kept trudging off despite the young man calling after him.

As the young man watched him go with a dejected expression, a round face popped up beside him.

"Hyung[3593], what are you doing here? I've been looking all over for you."

[3592] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi). A hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi); ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

[3593] *Hyung* is a Korean term a male speaker uses to address an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

The people nearby assumed the bright-eyed child had come looking for the slow older guy. They chuckled and lost interest.

They never dreamed that, at that very moment, the adorable child was driving a sinister voice into the young man's ear—one nobody else could hear.

"Didn't I tell you? Disappear without a word one more time and I'll kill you. Sword Saint's Disciple or not, I don't give a damn."

The young man, Cheongpung, answered innocently.

"Sorry. I was only going to be gone for a little while."

"Were you my enemy in a past life or something? Why do you keep doing this to this old man?"

"I had a reason."

"Then tell me."

"I ran out of candied hawthorn skewers[3594]."

"You little shit…!"

As he listened to the Slaughter Saint's deep sigh, Cheongpung watched the boy's retreating back.

Then he thought of someone and smiled to himself.

"Hehe. Did I ever tell you? When my Benefactor first saw me, the candied hawthorn skewers[3595]—"

"Shut up. Please."

In Qinghai, the Slaughter Saint was suffering.

[3594] *Bingtanghulu* are fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar, traditionally made with hawthorn berries.
[3595] *Bingtanghulu* are fruit skewers coated in hardened sugar, traditionally made with hawthorn berries.

Chapter 991

Whenever I lost consciousness or fell into a deep sleep, I found myself caught up in some kind of dream. It was nothing unusual anymore.

Someone once said dreams were a window into the mind. Worries I hadn't managed to shake and memories that still lingered would mix together and surface as the illusion we called a dream.

Everything in this world had a cause or a reason. Dreams were no different.

Right.

That had to be true.

At least, as far as I knew.

But then why…

Why am I having this dream?

I blinked slowly. My vision was a blur.

Everything was hazy.

Unlike my other dreams, which had been horrifyingly vivid, I couldn't even make out the illusions around me.

Then someone spoke, and I finally understood why I felt so groggy.

"Looks like you're awfully sleepy, little guy."

Sleepy.

As the realization sank in, I lifted my head.

No—*my head lifted* might be more accurate.

The blinking of my eyes, the movement of my head, even the voice slipping between my lips now—none of it was under my control.

"Yeah. I'm sleepy."

The voice sounded muffled, as though I were underwater, but one thing was clear.

I was a child.

Young enough that hearing myself whine didn't feel strange at all.

That answered one question, but another took its place.

Who was the unfamiliar man indulging the child's whining?

I've never heard his voice before.

A voice wasn't an ID card. I couldn't expect to recognize someone the instant I heard him. Still, anyone who appeared in my dreams ought to be familiar to me.

But everything here was strange. The voice coming through the haze. The scene playing out slowly, like a TV screen full of static.

Then I heard the child speak again through lips that weren't mine, and I understood where that strangeness came from.

"Dad. Can I go to sleep?"

If I'd been able to speak of my own accord, I would have groaned.

What I'd just realized was that startling—and that hard to understand.

Dad?

No. That couldn't be.

I could turn the oldest drawer of my memories upside down and shake it, and I still wouldn't find a memory like this.

The faint memory I had of my father's voice sounded nothing like the man I was hearing now.

Which meant this was—

Not my memory.

Just then, an inexplicable chill ran down my spine.

Then the unfamiliar man the child had called Dad spoke close to my ear.

"Have a good dream, my son."

A warm hand stroked my hair. His voice was gentle.

As my vision plunged into darkness, the man's final word echoed faintly.

"…a."

It was faint, but I'd heard it clearly.

A father speaking to his son. Calling him by name.

And at that moment, my thoughts ground to a halt with the shock of something I'd never expected.

Fwoosh.

Light poured down from beyond the pitch-black darkness, wrapping around the child lost in deep sleep.

No—around me.

If someone asked me what I usually saw first when I regained consciousness, I'd say the ceiling.

Or Hyuk Mujin, snoring in a corner under the pretense of standing guard. Or Jeok Cheongang's face as he waited by my side for me to wake.

This time, it was none of those.

"Hah… hah…"

I sprang upright and gasped for breath.

Was this what it felt like to be on the verge of suffocating?

My newly regained vision wavered like melting candle wax. Voices from every direction thundered in my ears.

"Medicine King…! Come here! Hurry!"

"…tain, Captain!"

“What the hell…!”

Was I still dreaming? Or was this real?

I couldn’t tell. I kept batting away the hands reaching for me, acting on instinct through the confusion.

Then someone seized my shoulder.

Even in the middle of all that, I could feel the strength in that hand with perfect clarity.

It hurt a little, but an unfamiliar warmth came through that hand, too.

Shaa…

My rigid body slowly relaxed.

Only then did I realize whose energy was flowing along the acupoint pathways known to just two people in this vast world—the Extreme Yang qi flowing through me.

“…Old Master.”

I let the words out with the breath I’d been holding. A voice I knew all too well answered.

“Stay just as you are for a moment. Just a moment.”

I closed my eyes as Jeok Cheongang told me to.

I reminded myself that this place I was in was real, not an illusion, and slowly calmed my heart, which was pounding without pause.

How much time passed like that?

After a while, I opened my eyes to a world that was quiet and clear.

And to a familiar face watching me with concern.

“You fool. Are you finally coming around?”

I hesitated before answering his abrupt question.

“More or less.”

“So not quite.”

“Could you hit me hard once?”

“What?”

“Just once. Don’t hold back at all. Put your whole heart into it.”

“…”

“Please.”

At my solemn request, Jeok Cheongang sighed and raised his fist.

“Fine.”

Whoosh.

White flames sprang up around his tightly clenched fist.

As I watched him prepare to fire off a move from the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist without further discussion, I spoke calmly.

“Wow, that’s hot.”

“What kind of nonsense is that? The Fire Gate Clan’s martial arts have always been hot.”

“If I can feel the heat, I think I’ve definitely come to my senses.”

Jeok Cheongang shook his head.

“Doesn’t look like it to me.”

“On second thought, I think I’m all right.”

“You said to put my whole heart into it.”

“Not to this extent.”

“Weren’t you the one who asked?”

“If you were going to take me *that* seriously, you should’ve refused three times first. Isn’t that only polite?”

“You lunatic. Do you think I’m Zhuge Cheongang?[3596] Quit flapping that mouth and brace yourself.”

Despite his words, Jeok Cheongang lowered his fist. He flicked his hand, and a water bottle on the bedside table shot toward me.

“What are you waiting for? Drink.”

“Thank you.”

I drained the full bottle without stopping for breath.

The cold water ran down my parched throat. At last, I felt like I could breathe again.

“Whew.”

“Well? Can you tell whether you’re dreaming or awake now?”

“More or less.”

At the same answer I’d given before, Jeok Cheongang clenched his fist again.

“And now?”

“…Wow, I’m awake! Definitely awake! The whole world is beautiful! I’m so happy to be alive!”

“Good. You’re finally back to the reckless little brat I know.”

“Was I not a moment ago?”

“Do you really have to ask? You woke up and immediately started thrashing around like you couldn’t tell up from down, so I sent everyone else out.”

“Hmm.”

Now that I thought about it, that did sound familiar.

I’d been overwhelmed with confusion and had instinctively fought off the hands trying to hold me.

[3596] The “three visits to the thatched cottage” refers to Liu Bei visiting the strategist Zhuge Liang three times to recruit him.

Besides, the proof was right in front of me.

“What a mess.”

I muttered as I looked at the fragments scattered everywhere, their original forms lost. Jeok Cheongang nodded emphatically in agreement.

“A hell of a mess.”

“Did I do this, too?”

“Half right, half wrong.”

“What do you mean…?”

“Your eldest brother was the one who made a scene. Built like a mountain, bawling his eyes out and insisting he couldn’t leave. I had no choice but to deal with him myself.”

I stared at Jeok Cheongang, eyes wide.

“Did you kill him?”

“Want me to kill you first?”

“No. I’m joking.”

“I’m not.”

“Oh.”

A long time ago, I would’ve clutched my ass like it came with built-in dynamite and started counting down. Not anymore.

I gave a quiet laugh instead of answering. Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue.

“Damn it. Now you really do think I’m worth less than dirt.”

“Come on, you’re sulking again. You know that’s not true.”

“Know what, my ass. More importantly… what caused this?”

The question came with a brief pause, his voice trailing off.

I opened my mouth, feeling the sweat that had soaked my back.

“It was just a dream.”

“What sort of nightmare?”

“No, it wasn’t exactly a nightmare… I don’t know. It was a strange dream. I can’t really describe it.”

Even as I answered, an odd feeling crept over me. I frowned.

What is it?

It felt strangely familiar.

But the sudden sense of déjà vu vanished when Jeok Cheongang spoke again, his voice grave.

“Tell me more. That nightmare could be a trace of the Heart Demon lurking inside you.”

I pushed aside my brief hesitation and answered.

“I don’t think so. It was a memory.”

“An unhappy memory can leave a trace of the Heart Demon, too. I’ve seen people trapped by their past until it destroyed them.”

I knew what Jeok Cheongang was worried about.

In modern terms, it was something like trauma.

For a Murim martial artist to break past their limits and reach the highest realms, powerful internal energy and martial arts weren’t enough.

They also needed the mental enlightenment gained through cultivating the mind.

Whether their path was good or evil, they had to reach an understanding of their own to keep walking it.

And for those who had begun that training, an unhealed illness of the mind could be devastating.

Like Old Master suffering from the infirmities of old age after losing Jopil. No—Jangcheon.

So Jeok Cheongang’s concern wasn’t an overreaction.

The world knew the Fire King Jeok Cheongang for a temper like hellfire. But inside him lay the caution and wisdom honed over many long years.

This time, though, I could answer him without hesitation.

“It’s not the Heart Demon.”

Jeok Cheongang’s expression hardened. I met his gaze and slowly continued.

“Because the memory I saw in the dream wasn’t mine to begin with.”

“What do you mean, it wasn’t yours?”

I swallowed a trembling breath.

And I remembered the man’s voice, faintly reaching the child as he fell into a deep sleep in that hazy dream.

No—the voice of another father.

“Have a good dream, my son… Taekyung.”

It was my memory, and at the same time, the memory of someone I could only call *you*.

Jin Taekyung, Third Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

The Shame of the Family, and the original owner of this body.

Chapter 992

The fact that Jeok Cheongang was the only person left in the room was a huge relief.

He already knew the truth about me, and he hadn't dismissed the words I'd spoken in a trembling voice as the ramblings of a lunatic.

"…So that was the last of it?"

"Yes. After I woke up, well, you know the rest, Old Master."

Was it the shock of finally facing the truth?

Or had something actually changed inside me?

I didn't know the exact reason, but I'd been left to flounder alone in a state of utter confusion.

No—maybe I still was.

"Damn it. That's downright bizarre."

Jeok Cheongang muttered the words like a groan, then studied me cautiously.

"What is it?"

"No, well… Has anything changed?"

"Changed? Of course."

"What?"

He cried out in alarm.

Cold sweat still clung unpleasantly to my skin. Apart from that, I could feel power surging through my whole body.

"Well, my mood's in the gutter, but I feel great physically."

Jeok Cheongang swallowed.

"A-and?"

"That's it."

"…That's all?"

"Yes."

He gave me a flat look, then sighed.

"Fine. In a situation like this, that's probably for the best."

I agreed, though I kept it to myself. I felt awful, but nothing had actually happened to me.

The bigger problem was what this inexplicable phenomenon meant.

"Just to be safe, let me ask you something. Has anything like this ever happened before?"

"No. Not once, from the beginning until now."

I answered firmly, then added, "That's what makes it so strange. If this is a sign of something to come…"

“Don’t say that. Words have a way of coming true. Keep that rotten-luck talk to yourself.”

“Seeds can sprout without anyone watering them. It’s a hundred times better to predict what we can and prepare for it.”

“…Even in a situation like this, you’ve got a silver tongue.”

Jeok Cheongang said it with a sour expression, but he didn’t exactly argue with me.

With far more years behind him than I had, he must already have known it deep down.

What was going to happen would happen, one way or another.

And this wasn’t just a coincidence.

“If your consciousness and Jin Taekyung’s had been mixed together from the beginning… Damn it. I don’t know what to call him. Fine, if your consciousness and that good-for-nothing’s had been mixed together, wouldn’t that make sense?”

After a brief silence, I considered his question, then shook my head.

“I don’t think so. No, I’m sure that’s not it.”

“What makes you say that?”

“I had no memories at all when I first arrived. If our consciousnesses had merged, as you say, then at least some tiny memory should’ve remained. That’s the only way it would add up.”

I still remembered that time clearly.

When I first opened my eyes in the pleasure house, I didn’t even know Murim was another world rather than a virtual reality game.

I spoke with Wolhwa without knowing exactly who I was or where I was. That conversation was how I managed to learn even the bare minimum.

And even that was so basic I had to lie to Jin Wikyung and tell him my memories were jumbled.

If even the tiniest fragment of a memory had remained, I could’ve adjusted to this strange world much faster.

You know how it goes in web novels. The protagonist gets hit with a splitting headache, and a flood of memories comes rushing in.

But reality and fiction were worlds apart.

All I’d been given when I first set foot here was the same three-syllable name I’d had in the modern world.

And a body half-rotted from drink and women.

“…”

Now that I thought about it, that pissed me the fuck off.

Anyway, my conclusion was simple.

My consciousness and that of this world's Jin Taekyung, who'd been nothing but a good-for-nothing, were completely separate.

No—they *had been* separate.

At least until today, before I had that strange dream.

"You're so certain, so I'll take your word for it for now. But the fact that the good-for-nothing's memories appeared, even if only in a dream…"

His words trailed off.

Jeok Cheongang held my gaze, his expression grave. At last, he continued.

"Maybe some part of that good-for-nothing's consciousness was inside you from the beginning."

A groan escaped me before I could stop it.

It was one of the theories I'd been considering myself, but hearing someone else say it gave it a whole different weight.

Damn it. What is this, one house with two families?

There had been a time when I'd wondered about this, too.

It was after I'd spent a while living as Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan—more precisely, after I realized this strange world wasn't a game but another reality.

Two worlds.

Two people who'd lived different lives under the same name.

Even if my head were made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron, it would've been only natural to wonder about it at least once.

If this body wasn't a game character…

Then what had happened to its original owner?

His body was still here, so where was that good-for-nothing's soul?

But at some point, I'd had to stop dwelling on it. Crises kept coming at me, one after another. I couldn't afford to cling to a question I had no way to answer.

I'd simply assumed he'd disappeared the moment I took over this body.

Maybe whoever had made the piece-of-junk capsule that brought me here had thought that was the better outcome, too.

But that wasn't what happened?

For once, I didn't know what to say.

I rubbed my stomach, wearing an expression I couldn't have described if I'd tried.

Jeok Cheongang watched me in silence until he finally spoke.

"I understand you're feeling conflicted, but what the hell are you rubbing your stomach for? It's not like you're pregnant. You're a hairy man, for crying out loud."

"…I did it without thinking. Why do you have to put it like that?"

Was this the danger of media?

The moment I thought there might be something inside me, my hand had gone to my stomach on instinct.

Must be a side effect of watching too many commercials about babies and toddlers, I muttered to myself. Then I quietly moved my hand from my stomach to my chest and looked at Jeok Cheongang.

“Did something land on your chest, too? Are you all worked up, huh? Burning up with rage?”

“…I was just trying it out.”

“Fine, let’s say so. You went from your stomach to your chest. Where were you planning to touch next?”

“My head.”

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation.

“Don’t. You’ll look like an idiot.”

“Yes, sir.”

I was already starting to regret it. I snatched my hand back, and Jeok Cheongang let out a deep sigh.

“What’s wrong?”

“Seeing the way you carry on makes me worry.”

“About what?”

“From what I’ve heard, that good-for-nothing was a complete idiot. If he suddenly took over your body one day, I might not even notice.”

“Ah, because I’m just as much of an idiot?”

“Exactly. Nothing to add, nothing to take away.”

“Come on, that’s a little harsh. You’re hurting my feelings.”

“What are you going to do if your feelings are hurt? What can you even do? Hm? You…”

“Hey, why are you getting worked up all of a sudden? Calm down. Take it easy.”

Thankfully, Jeok Cheongang came to his senses at the last moment. He spoke calmly, as though nothing had happened.

“Anyway, keep discussing this with me. Do you understand?”

“I was planning to. Who else could I talk to about something like this, if not you?”

It wasn’t a choice. It was a necessity.

If I told people and even one word got out, I’d go from Divine Dragon to Mad Dragon in no time.

Jeok Cheongang believed me because of what he’d seen and experienced himself. But if the truth about me became known throughout the world, the orthodox faction’s chivalrous heroes would take numbers and line up to tear me apart for using unprecedented dark arts.

Who knew? Maybe I'd become the Lord of Heaven's classmate as a public enemy of Murim.

But in response to my obvious answer, Jeok Cheongang shook his head.

"No. There's one more person besides me. Have you already forgotten?"

"Who… Oh."

I'd asked on instinct. Now I clicked my tongue.

Right. There was someone else.

Someone who wasn't close enough for me to have a deep conversation with about something like this, but who was still somewhat near the truth.

That's right. The Bow Saint.

I was still a little wary of her.

No—not a little. Very.

I have no idea what she's thinking.

The distance between us never seemed to shrink.

Even when we'd had several chances to talk at length while staying in the Imperial Palace, we'd never crossed the line she'd drawn.

An invisible wall stood between the Bow Saint and me.

No, she seemed to treat everyone that way. Whenever anyone tried to break through that wall and get closer, she quietly withdrew.

Like magnets with the same pole facing each other.

As if that were the answer.

But the Bow Saint might know something. She knows at least part of the truth.

She'd believed the outlandish contents of a letter and spent decades wandering the world in search of me—or, more precisely, the "chosen one."

Aside from Jeok Cheongang, who was standing right in front of me, and the mysterious absolute being known as the Martial God, whose very survival was uncertain, the Bow Saint was unquestionably the right person to ask.

Of course, first she'd have to agree to talk.

"Old Master. Then, by any chance…"

Before I could finish, Jeok Cheongang guessed what I was about to say and shook his head.

"Meeting the Bow Saint right now isn't possible. She still hasn't returned from Hebei."

"Hebei…"

"The situation hasn't fully settled down. Even the Family Head of the Peng Family hasn't been able to return yet, so it'll probably take a little longer."

Hebei. The Peng Family.

At the sound of those two words, something stirred in a corner of my chest.

Someone came to mind—someone who'd done his best for everyone until the very last moment of his life, then left.

"The Thunderbolt Saber King… Is he…?"

I had to force the question out.

"He's gone," Jeok Cheongang answered. Then he added, "He was smiling. So brightly I could hardly stand to look at him."

"…!"

"That's enough. That's all that matters."

I nodded quietly instead of answering.

Then Jeok Cheongang left, and silence settled into the space he'd occupied.

A quiet that had finally come at long last—one I hadn't felt in a very long time.

Open System window.

Ding.

A clear chime shattered the silence.

Chapter 993

Open System window.

The moment I muttered that short command in my mind—

Ding. Ding. Diiiing!

A familiar, clear chime rang out, and countless holographic windows poured from the air as if a dam had burst.

> **System** Sudden Quest, **Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body**, completed successfully!
>
> Quest rewards have been issued!
>
> Your **internal energy** has increased dramatically!
>
> You have gained a large amount of **EXP**!
>
> You have received 20 bonus stat points!
>
> Level up!
>
> **Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body** is a technique with such a low chance of success that no martial artist dares attempt it anymore. We commend your patience and audacity in succeeding at the process twice.
>
> You have earned the rare achievement **You Did That Twice. You Did That Twice.**
>
> Achievement rewards have been issued!
>
> You have gained a large amount of **EXP**!
>
> Your **Endurance** has increased dramatically!

The first things that caught my eye were the System messages announcing the completed Quest and earned achievement.

I'd only leveled up once, but the stat increase from successfully completing Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body was enormous.

I skimmed the messages, then erased a dozen or so with a single wave of my hand. There were still more holographic windows I needed to check.

> **System** Successfully absorbed the internal energy of the **Heavenly Power Demon**!
>
> Successfully absorbed the internal energy of the **Thunderbolt Saber King**!
>
> The nature of **Scorching Yang Qi** is changing. The new flame born deep within your body will burn fiercer and hotter than ever!
>
> He who conquers the great sea will look down upon the world, but he who climbs the peak closest to heaven will look down even upon the great sea.

> Congratulations! Your **Middle Dantian** has been fully opened!
>
> You have reached the **Supreme Peak** realm!
>
> Sudden Quest, **Bone Transformation**, has begun. You cannot refuse this Quest!
>
> Sudden Quest, **Bone Transformation**, completed successfully!
>
> You can now draw in and release qi with great freedom. Your Muscles and Bones, now perfect in themselves, even reject impure qi!
>
> You have earned the great achievement **Full-Body Plastic Surgery**!
>
> Quest and achievement rewards have been issued!
>
> All attributes have increased significantly! Open the **Status Window** to check the details.
>
> You have received 30 bonus stat points!
>
> You have gained a large amount of **EXP** and **Fame**!
>
> Level up!

As I read through the holographic windows pouring out one after another, only one thought came to mind.

This is insane.

Of course, I'd expected massive rewards.

The Thunderbolt Saber King, Peng Cheolhu.

The power that giant, who'd defined an entire era, had passed on to me at the cost of what little life he had left was just as pure as it was immense.

Even so, the rewards listed by the System went far beyond what I'd expected.

Two level-ups, a huge number of bonus points on top of that, and a boost to all my attributes.

I'll have to check the details to see just how much my attributes increased, but even so, if I add all this together…

It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say I'd gained more than ten levels in one go.

No, in practice, it was even better than that.

The stronger I got, the farther away my next level-up seemed. The EXP required rose exponentially with each level, but the huge number of stat points I'd just received as a reward was pure bonus.

I'm in debt. Deep in debt.

Even with all those incredible rewards, I felt conflicted.

Caught between joy and bitterness, I remembered the Thunderbolt Saber King smiling brightly as he said he would pass everything he had on to me.

And with him, I remembered all the victims who'd fallen at Eight Spring Gorge that day, when the chrysanthemums covering the mountain had turned red and the bodies of people and horses had piled up like mountains.

I etched one thing deep in my heart: these enormous rewards had been paid for with the lives of the dead.

I'll repay this debt… no matter what.

I'd never been well-off, and debt had always been a miserable thing to me. But not this time.

I was looking toward the same place they were.

The day I finally paid it all back, the peace everyone wanted would arrive.

And to make that happen, I had to endure and overcome whatever hardships came my way.

I couldn't collapse under my grief or settle for where I was. I had to keep moving higher, with no thought of giving up.

Toward the place I'd glimpsed while completing Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body, hidden behind thick, billowing clouds.

Toward the sky above the summit.

Right. The upper dantian.

Of course, I knew it wouldn't be easy.

I couldn't even be sure whether the Three Saints, the greatest masters in the Central Plains, or Jeok Cheongang, who stood shoulder to shoulder with them, had opened their upper dantian.

No, even if they've already reached that stage, there must still be differences between them.

Everything had its proper order.

I'd widened a narrow stream into a vast sea. Now I had to climb a mountain peak that rose as if it would pierce the clouds.

Until now, I'd grown at a terrifying pace thanks to the System I'd gained by chance and countless fortuitous encounters. But even I had been stopped by the clouds.

I still couldn't reach the absolute beings who looked down on the lower world from above them.

What if I'd ridden that momentum and kept pushing forward back then?

A pang of regret struck me.

But I already knew the answer.

I would've failed. And the odds would've been very high.

Trying to break through to the upper dantian in those circumstances wouldn't have been a challenge. It would've been a gamble.

Even I, despite having fully opened my Middle Dantian and feeling an intense surge of elation, had instinctively understood the difference between courage and recklessness—and pulled back.

The more I thought about it, the more indescribably frustrating it felt. But looking at it objectively, it had been a very good decision…

Wait.

What was this feeling?

I furrowed my brow and thought back to the excruciating process of Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body, then to the strange dream born of memories that weren't mine.

But that wasn't all.

The inexplicable déjà vu sweeping through me pointed to the trace of a memory worn away somewhere between the two.

"Decision. A good decision… I'm sure I heard that somewhere."

My lips moved on their own. The voice that came out sounded unfamiliar, as though it belonged to someone else.

How much time passed?

I stared blankly into empty air, muttering the same words over and over like a man in a trance. At last, I recovered part of the memory I'd forgotten.

Someone definitely said something like that. Not in reality, but inside my consciousness.

My eyes stung. I'd forgotten even to blink.

After turning the thought over for so long, my head felt hot.

No—an invisible little awl was slowly burrowing into my mind.

A headache slowly spread through me.

But even as the pain made me wince, I kept searching my memory. I groped through the darkness for a tiny fragment hidden behind larger memories.

And finally—

I remembered.

I remembered realizing it wasn't time yet and turning away from the upper dantian beyond the clouds.

Then, as I slipped into the world of No-self, someone's words echoed faintly in my ear.

That was a good decision. Just like back then.

"…!"

My eyes flew wide open.

Because I'd realized who the voice belonged to?

No.

Because an immense pain had suddenly struck me.

Hk.

I sucked in a breath on instinct. Clenching my teeth wasn't enough; I squeezed my eyes shut, too.

The headache that had been slowly burrowing into my mind like an invisible awl had grown as huge as the long acupuncture needle the Medicine King Hall Master carried around like a prized weapon. Now it was tearing through my head.

What the hell is this…!

With my vision gone white, I flailed my limbs like someone on the verge of drowning.

Even then, I couldn't let go of the one question still unanswered in my mind.

Who did that voice, which had rung out like a hallucination at the last moment, belong to?

Who could speak to me in a space inside my mind rather than in the real world?

How? How could they do that?

There was one thing I could be sure of.

The voice I'd heard belonged neither to Jeok Cheongang nor, least of all, to the Thunderbolt Saber King.

And aside from those two old martial-world veterans, no one else could have communicated with me then.

Then who was it?

I genuinely wanted to know. Even as it felt like my head was splitting open, I wanted to know.

Who owned that voice, and how had they approached me and whispered without any of us noticing?

At the same time, I wanted to ask:

How did you know me?

Just like back then… That's what they said. I'm sure of it.

There was no doubt.

I didn't know them, but they knew me.

I couldn't say when or where we'd met, but today wasn't the first time we'd encountered each other.

But…

Why can't I remember anything? Why?

I remembered only what they'd said. I couldn't distinguish the pitch or depth of their voice, or even their gender.

I couldn't guess whether they were a woman or a man—or, if they were a man, how old they might be.

All I could vaguely recall was the sensation of that moment, dredged up at the cost of enduring that terrible headache.

A strange familiarity.

The voice seemed as unfamiliar as something I'd never heard before, yet faintly, peculiarly familiar.

And that was all I could recover.

Whoosh!

A flash of light exploded. The whiteness in my vision slowly receded, and my blurred sight began to come back into focus.

"…Ah."

I let out the breath I'd been holding and realized that the pain, which had seemed as though it would go on forever, had finally ended.

And with it, the memory I'd been allowed to recover had reached its limit.

Damn it.

I stared silently at my fingertips, still trembling from the pain, then curled them into a tight fist.

Crunch.

The skin of my palm, now almost like iron after Bone Transformation, pressed taut against my sharp fingernails.

Perhaps it was the strange turmoil of my emotions.

At that very moment, the vast qi sleeping inside my body began to boil—

Ding.

> **System** A new Quest, **Unknown Voice**, has been created.
> You cannot choose whether to accept this Quest.
> The Quest will proceed by force.
> Would you like to check the newly updated Quest information?

Unknown Voice.

I stared at the Quest title on the holographic window, then parted my tightly shut lips.

"Yes."

Chapter 994

The System often—maybe even pretty frequently—sprang clues on me in the form of Quests without making clear what they meant.

Just like now.

> **System Quest**
>
> **Unknown Voice**
>
> At some point, you became aware of the voice of someone whose identity you cannot determine.
>
> This may or may not be the first time this has happened, but one thing is certain.
>
> In the not-too-distant future, you may come face-to-face with the owner of that voice.
>
> May that meeting not be an unhappy one.
>
> **Grade:** None
>
> **Restriction:** Jin Taekyung
>
> **Objective:** Continue to survive (In progress)
>
> **Reward:** ???
>
> **Failure:** ???

The moment I saw the translucent holographic window, only one thought came to mind.

Here we fucking go again.

What, would the screen go blue if it gave me a straight answer?

The whole description was vague, as if someone had hidden it in fog.

This wasn't the first time I'd received a Quest like this, of course. That didn't make it any easier to get used to.

But at the same time—

It's something I have to go through.

As I knew from experience, the System wasn't an answer sheet.

It was more like a signpost, pointing me in a direction and telling me what lay ahead.

Depending on my choices, the arrows on that sign might change. Sometimes, like now, I had to figure out what they meant.

So I read the words in the holographic window again and again, trying to work out what those Twenty Questions-style clues were hiding.

The last two sentences of the Quest description, in particular, caught my eye.

I might meet the owner of that unknown voice? And in the not-too-distant future?

Not too distant, huh.

Time was relative, so that was a pretty vague way to put it.

A year could feel long and distant to a little kid with a runny nose, but to a white-haired old man, it might pass in the blink of an eye.

I couldn't guess how much time the System meant by "not too distant."

A few days. A few months. Or… No. Even the System couldn't be so shameless as to lump years together under that phrase.

Days would be too soon, and years would be too long. A few months seems like the reasonable guess.

Then what was that last line about the meeting not being unhappy?

And who on earth was the owner of that unknown voice—the person at the heart of this riddle of a Quest?

Someone who could approach without me, the Thunderbolt Saber King, or even the Old Master noticing. Someone who could intrude into my own inner world.

While Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body was underway, the Thunderbolt Saber King and I had our hands full giving and receiving energy. But Jeok Cheongang was different.

He'd stood guard throughout that dangerous technique, every sense strained to its limit.

For someone to evade his notice and speak to me should have been impossible. He was a Supreme Peak master who now stood shoulder to shoulder with the Three Saints, beyond even the Ten Kings.

Well, strictly speaking, it wasn't *completely* impossible.

If they were the greatest assassin of all time, with a concealment technique unlike anything ever seen before—or a master at least two moves ahead of the Old Master…

As far as I knew, only two people in the world could meet those minimum requirements.

The first was undoubtedly the greatest assassin of all time, but I couldn't be sure they had any reason to do this—or that they could pull it off.

The other one was different.

A wonder of the world itself.

The sky looking down over this vast land alone. A being who, though human, had come to be called a god.

"…The Martial God?"

The two syllables slipped from my lips before I realized it. A shiver ran down my spine.

The Martial God. The Martial God himself?

That can't be right.

It had been half a century since the Martial God disappeared.

He'd vanished as suddenly as he'd first appeared, and no one under heaven knew where he was now.

No one could even say for sure whether he was alive or dead.

Not even the Bow Saint, who'd found me through the letter he'd left behind.

And now he'd suddenly reveal his presence like this?

No way.

But realistically, the Martial God was the only person capable of what had happened today.

As far as I knew, he alone was an overwhelming presence beyond even the superhumans known as the Three Saints.

And perhaps I knew more about the truth hidden behind the Martial God than anyone else under heaven.

If my guess is right…

A thought flashed through my mind, and my heart began to pound.

I remembered the first deep conversation I'd had with the Bow Saint at the Imperial Palace. Amid the hectic days that followed, there had been one name I could only turn over in the back of my mind.

Now it filled my thoughts.

Cheon Taemin.

Another absolute being, existing beyond a distant space.

Just as the Martial God had fought the Heavenly Demon and restored peace, Cheon Taemin was a hero who'd saved humanity from the demon known as the Demon King Asmodeus.

I could still see him clearly in the Ares Guild's restricted area, unconscious as if in a deep sleep, attached to a life-support system that combined Magic and science.

Over that image, I could faintly hear a woman's voice.

"He left a message for the chosen one."

"A message? What does that mean?"

"Divine strength. He said the chosen one should overcome the crisis with that divine strength and a Will like steel. Just as…"

That day, the Bow Saint had watched me with a deep, solemn gaze.

Then her voice had echoed faintly in my ears, like a distant refrain.

"Just as you did."

I still remembered the shock I'd felt in that moment.

No—I'd remember it until the day I died.

I'd vaguely entertained the thought before, only to laugh at myself and shake my head. Then an unexpected piece of the puzzle had fallen into place.

Divine strength.

A strange power possessed only by the chosen one.

The supernatural ability that belonged to me now—and had belonged to the Martial God in the past.

If the message the Martial God had left the Bow Saint meant what I thought it did, it could mean only one thing.

System user. Player.

That was probably the Martial God's true identity.

The truth hidden behind an unparalleled hero the likes of whom had never been seen before, and would never be seen again: a man who'd appeared out of nowhere, saved a world in turmoil, then disappeared.

But if that theory was true…

Cheon Taemin and the Martial God can't possibly be the same person.

According to the capsule's user manual, the System was a power granted to only one person.

The moment my thoughts reached that point, a headache struck.

Two heroes in different worlds.

Their actions were astonishingly alike. The more I learned about them, the more I found myself wondering whether Cheon Taemin or the Martial God might have had the same ability as me. Whether the two of them might even be the same person.

But now I didn't know what to think.

What connection existed between the Martial God and Cheon Taemin? If they were two entirely different people, what truth were they hiding?

There was one thing I did know: how to resolve at least some of my doubts—and the headache still stabbing at my mind like a needle.

I'm going back. Right now.

That's right.

The answer didn't have to be found in just one place.

The modern world and Murim. In these two worlds connected by a power I couldn't begin to explain, I had to find a clear answer to my question.

And right now was the perfect time.

I'd completed the important Quest concerning the crisis in Shanxi Province, and the Logout function it had blocked was available again.

One month. Maybe two. That should be enough.

Learning more about Cheon Taemin wasn't my only reason to go back.

I also had to deal with the fallout from the Doppelganger incident, which had happened right before I last Logged In.

On top of that, the ominous words it had left behind before its Erasure hinted at more trouble to come. Even through the frantic days in Murim, they'd bothered me like a fish bone stuck in my throat.

I'll find out when I get back. Why the Doppelganger said those things. What it went that far for.

Now that I'd made up my mind, there was no hesitation. I lay straight on the bed and pulled the covers up to my neck.

Even if I spent a couple of months in the modern world, only about three shichen[3597] would pass in Murim.

I didn't know whose presence was hurrying toward me from somewhere far beyond the window, but by the time they reached my room, all they'd find was me already gone to the modern world—or rather, fast asleep.

Logout.

I slowly closed my eyes and gave the familiar command. The next moment, I realized something.

Some things in this world didn't go the way you expected.

Bip-bip-bip!

> **System** Logout failed!
> The System has rejected your Logout command!
> Error! Error!
> Due to a System error, the Logout function has been temporarily disabled!
> Unknown error! Temporary Maintenance has begun!

...What?

My eyes flew open, even though I hadn't meant to open them.

But the System's voice in my ears hadn't changed. Neither had the dozens of error messages floating in the air. Confusion seized me.

Logout rejected? Why on earth?

This had never happened before.

No—it had, but only when I was in the middle of an important Quest. Even then, it hadn't happened like this.

System error? Temporary Maintenance?

An update, sure. But I'd never heard of anything like this.

An error in the System, which had always been absolute? How could that be possible?

"What the...!"

[3597] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

A groan escaped me. I bit down hard and shouted over and over in my mind.

Logout! Logout!

But nothing changed.

Nothing at all.

The holographic windows that poured out with every command showed only the words “System error.” Faced with this unbelievable reality, all I could do was stare blankly and take it in.

Actually, if I had to name one more thing I could do, it was let the person whose presence had drawn close to the door know that he was an unwelcome guest before he entered my room.

“Don’t come in. I’m… damn it. Anyway, I’m busy.”

I assumed it was Hyuk Mujin without even looking. If it wasn’t him, it had to be one of the Fire Dragon Pavilion members.

But my guess was just as spectacularly wrong as I’d been when I tried to Logout.

Click.

“Must be because we’re brothers. Even on this, we’re of one mind.”

The next moment, the unwelcome guest opened the door without hesitation. No—it was Jin Wikyung, his expression heavy and grave.

The sight of him sent a chill down my spine.

Chapter 995

Some conversations don’t need many words.

Especially when the matter is urgent.

That was true of my conversation with Jin Wikyung, who’d come to my room out of the blue. It lasted less than fifteen minutes.

But what he told me weighed as heavily as a massive boulder. As soon as he left, I called everyone together—the people who could help me bear that weight.

Rattle.

“Well, I’ll be damned. Live long enough and you see everything. Who’d have thought martial-world lowlifes like us would ever lay eyes on the Marquis of Shangshan?”

Namho tossed out the silly joke the moment the door opened, and I couldn’t help laughing.

For two reasons.

First, seeing Namho again—or rather, seeing all of them—felt good. Comfortable, too, as though it had been ages since we’d met.

Second, because Namho was sitting astride Taishan’s shoulders as though that were the most natural thing in the world. It was ridiculous.

“What are you doing?”

“What does it look like? Sitting.”

“I can see that. Why are you sitting *there*?”

“Easy. It’s incredibly comfortable. This fellow’s a real find.”

Namho smiled with the satisfaction of an inventor who’d made a world-changing discovery, then patted the top of Taishan’s head.

“What are you waiting for? Get inside.”

Taishan stood blankly in the doorway. He glanced off into the distance before answering.

“Taishan. Feet won’t move. Must be hungry.”

“What the hell are you talking about? The jerky you stuffed into your mouth barely fifteen minutes ago amounted to a whole calf.”

“…”

Apparently, the ride was pay-as-you-go.

And the mileage was terrible.

“Don’t remember. Hungry.”

“You bottomless pit…”

With a deep sigh, Namho pulled a piece of taffy from his sleeve and waved it in front of Taishan’s eyes.

“There. Will you move now?”

In that instant, Taishan’s eyes narrowed to razor-sharp slits.

“Just one?”

“Damn it. I’ll give you another as soon as we get back.”

“Three.”

“You little bandit. Not a chance. Two. That’s my final offer, so think carefully.”

Taishan’s resolve was beginning to waver when a voice sounded from behind his enormous body, ending the negotiations.

“Move. Now. Or I’ll personally stab each of you twice.”

“…!”

“…!”

“What, two stabs each aren’t enough? Should I make it three?”

Her voice was low and calm, which somehow made the warning more dangerous. Taishan swallowed hard and hurried into the room.

He even snatched the taffy Namho had been waving in front of him.

With the doorway finally clear, Ju Hwaran—the one who’d put an end to the rush-hour jam—strode toward me. She called out in a voice suddenly thick with emotion, as though nothing had happened.

“Young Master Jin! No, Benefactor! No, Pavilion Master!”

“…”

I was pretty sure I’d asked her several times to pick one.

It was funny, but her sudden change of attitude caught me off guard. While I floundered, her eyes filled with tears.

“I’m sorry I arrived so late during the last battle. You must’ve had such a hard time.”

Over Ju Hwaran’s shoulder, Sama Pyo stood like an invisible man and muttered to himself.

“I’d guess the enemies had a harder time.”

Song Ilseom, arms crossed and his willow-leaf saber tucked against his chest as always, nodded.

“Judging by the aftermath, he was a monster. The enemies were smashed to pieces.”

Jaw clenched, Ju Hwaran ignored the voices behind her and continued.

“Were you hurt? Are you all right now?”

Sama Pyo and Song Ilseom at least had some sense. They slipped away at the right moment instead of barging in like Hyuk Mujin.

“Come on, Young Lady Ju. Why ask how someone’s feeling when he went through Bone Transformation just the other day—”

A chill settled over the room.

I didn’t know what expression Ju Hwaran had on her face as she slowly turned around, but I saw terror spread across Hyuk Mujin’s face as his voice trailed off. I decided I’d go on living without ever finding out.

“Mujin, shut your blabbering mouth. Young Lady Ju, I’m fine. Completely fine, so please don’t worry. And Taishan, I have something important to say, so swallow that taffy before we start—oh, you’ve finished it already. Did you chew it, or drink it?”

With Taishan’s magic trick over—and me wondering whether taffy might actually be a liquid—I’d finally sorted out the traffic. Namho gave me an uneasy look.

“Something important, huh? For some reason, I already have a very bad feeling about this… Am I just being an old worrywart?”

“If only that were all.”

I wasn’t the one who said it.

The last guest, Jeok Cheongang, strode into the room and gave me a nod.

“Tell them what’s happening beyond Shanxi Province.”

His grave eyes told me he’d heard the same news I had.

I looked silently from one face to the next in the now-crowded room. At last, I spoke.

“Something troubling is happening in the west.”

“The west? Where in the west…?”

As expected, Namho was the first to react. His brow furrowed as he spoke, then his narrow eyes widened.

“Y-you don’t mean…?”

“Yes. The place you’re thinking of.”

I nodded, then spoke in a heavy voice.

The far western edge, the birthplace of the Heavenly Demon Divine Cult—called the Demonic Cult in the Central Plains—and now the home base of Dark Heaven. That accursed land.

“Xinjiang.”

“…!”

“…!”

A massive shock swept through the room like an invisible wave.

When did Murim—that other world within the world—and the martial artists who lived in it first come into being?

No one knew for sure.

Oral traditions passed down through the generations, along with the few surviving lines in records from the distant past, led many to claim that Shaolin Temple in Henan had begun Murim's long history. In time, that became the accepted account.

Jeok Cheongang had told me something different while I was enduring grueling training on Mount Jiuhua.

"History is shaped and pieced together. People believe what they want to believe—whatever suits them."

Back then, Jeok Cheongang had been suffering from the infirmities of old age, and he'd begun reminiscing more often. Or rather, I'd half-begged him to. I thought I'd read somewhere that recalling and revisiting old memories whenever he had time might slow the illness's progression.

And among Jeok Cheongang's vast store of knowledge were secret histories of Murim that few people knew.

"Light and darkness go hand in hand. The idea that martial arts were born in Shaolin, packed with fellows trying to become Buddhas, is absurd enough. But did you think no one would try to use such power for evil?"

"Are you saying…?"

"That's right. According to records left by our sect's forebears, the Demonic Cult came into being that way, too. No one knows exactly when, but it was probably around the same time as Shaolin Temple."

Murim could only have become a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords because the age itself was so chaotic.

The Shaolin warrior monks learned martial arts to protect. Others, on encountering that astonishing power, learned martial arts to conquer the world.

"People of every stripe must've gathered from all directions, in droves. They used martial arts to wield such mysterious power that they hardly seemed human. Just imagine how astonished everyone must've been."

There must have been only a few dozen of them at first.

The world around them was dark even in daylight. Having encountered a power like a great light, they soon became followers and spread in every direction.

They told others what they'd seen with their own eyes. When people refused to believe them, they took hold of their sleeves and led them to him.

To the man with that unbelievable power. To the leader who would protect them in this wretched age of chaos.

The followers grew to hundreds, then thousands, and finally a hundred thousand. Their leader declared himself the Cult Leader and a divine man sent by Heaven.

"That was the beginning of the Heavenly Demon and the Demonic Cult."

Jeok Cheongang had also said that they probably hadn't called themselves the Heavenly Demon or the Demonic Cult from the very beginning.

What mattered was that the first Heavenly Demon never conquered the world. He and his followers settled instead in a desert on the western frontier.

Over nearly a thousand years, they sometimes turned their blades on one another. After several divisions and reunifications, they brought about the Great Faction War, a calamity of enormous scale.

Throughout those long years, the scorching desert ruled absolutely by Fiends became a Land of Ruin that even Murim of the Central Plains couldn't hope to challenge.

And so it remained, even now that a new shadow called Dark Heaven had fallen across it.

But…

"Something unprecedented is happening in *that* Xinjiang?"

A long silence had followed my brief account. Namho's question finally broke it, and I nodded.

"That's what I heard."

"Where did the information come from?"

"Where do you think?"

I pointed upward. Namho let out a weary breath.

"The Murim Alliance… No, the Hidden Shadow Pavilion."

"I heard they lost more than thirty elite agents. After their first and last messenger eagle, all contact was lost."

"Damn it. Then there's no room for doubt. How many enemies are we looking at?"

"That…"

Even I couldn't bring myself to answer right away. Namho groaned at the look on my face.

"I see. The Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples all over again."

"Maybe more than that. At least, that's what the information I received suggests."

More important, these enemies would be far stronger and more terrifying than the Demonic Cult's followers had been fifty years ago.

The desert no longer belonged to the Demonic Cult. It belonged to Dark Heaven.

They weren't merely the successors of the Demonic Cult under a different name. They were a new group of followers, ruled by a power incomparably stronger and more dangerous.

Could that be why Logout was suddenly blocked?

The thought crossed my mind, but I shook my head.

No. That wasn't it.

The Quest hadn't appeared yet, because I hadn't made my choice.

Now was the moment to make it.

"From this moment on, we're heading west."

Ding.

An alert sounded, announcing a new Quest.

Chapter 996

Sometimes, I wonder.

Maybe the real benefit of circulating your qi isn't growing stronger by accumulating internal energy. Maybe it's calming your mind.

Kwoooosh.

I had no idea how much time had passed.

I simply let myself be carried by the swift, powerful current.

At last, the wave of internal energy swept through the Eight Extraordinary Meridians and hundreds of acupoints. The moment I gathered it in, I opened my eyes to a breathless silence.

Ding.

A clear chime rang out right on cue.

As the alert confirmed that I'd successfully finished circulating my qi, I calmly examined the energy within me.

The very best.

The words came to mind without hesitation, and there wasn't a shred of exaggeration in them.

That's right.

I'm stronger now than I've ever been.

I'd fully absorbed the Heavenly Power Demon's energy, which had remained inside me for quite some time without being completely assimilated, and the Thunderbolt Saber King's as well.

Four jiazi[3598].

An incredible amount of internal energy—especially considering my age and how long I'd been practicing martial arts.

A greenhorn just starting out in Murim might wonder why I'd gained only one jiazi[3599] after receiving Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body from two old masters. But martial artists who'd reached a certain realm knew better.

Martial arts weren't as simple as one plus one.

No matter how much internal energy you possessed, if its essence was impure, you couldn't draw out even half of it. You couldn't control it properly, either.

In that sense, the four jiazi[3600] of internal energy reborn through complete fusion was pure power I could control entirely.

[3598] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar. As a measure of accumulated internal energy, four jiazi represents 240 years.

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If the Heavenly Power Demon and the Thunderbolt Saber King had been in their usual condition when they transferred their energy, I might've grown even stronger, but…

Wanting more would be greedy.

Even I, with the mysterious divine strength known as the System, had risked my life twice while undergoing Transmitting Internal Energy Across the Body.

And yet I couldn't help feeling a little disappointed. The reason was the reality I'd faced the moment I finished circulating my qi.

SYSTEM

Quest
Desert Mirage
You have learned of troubling signs in Xinjiang, at the far western edge of your world.
A cursed land, long separated from the Central Plains.
A group is crossing the scorching desert, where nothing exists but hot sand and the blazing sun, and heading toward the center of the world. But their true nature remains hidden behind a dense mirage.
Please remember. Never forget.
The world—and the heavens—are changing.
Nothing is set in stone.
The countless enemies drawing near from far away, even now, may prove to be no more than a momentary spark.
Or they may become a hellfire that brings the world to ruin.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Head west (Incomplete)
Reward: A large amount of EXP and Fame
Follow-up Quests depending on your choice
Failure: ???

I'd read the Quest window dozens of times already, ever since sending the Fire Dragon Pavilion members away to prepare for the perilous journey ahead.

I gestured it away from the corner of my vision and remembered the conversation I'd had with Jin Wikyung two hours earlier.

"If Dark Heaven crosses Xinjiang and cuts through the desert, as the information from the Hidden Shadow Pavilion suggests, where would it focus its attack?"

"The Murim Alliance is considering three possibilities at once. They might advance through Tibet, which could be considered part of the Outer Lands. They might

target Gansu Province, where the Kongtong Sect and Black Dragon Demon Gate are holding their ground. But the most dangerous place is probably…”

“Qinghai. The Kunlun Sect, then.”

“That’s right. Kunlun Mountain is a natural fortress, but for Dark Heaven, which has its sights on the Central Plains, it’s also the first obstacle they must overcome. They won’t leave Qinghai alone.”

Shanxi Province was a remote backwater, but it was nothing compared to Qinghai, at the westernmost edge of the Central Plains.

Its highlands included terrain so rugged it was downright forbidding, making it difficult to produce abundant supplies. Commerce and industry hadn’t developed much, either, thanks to the Demonic Cult’s long hold over the desert.

Merchants would risk their lives for profit, but even they couldn’t cross a desert knowing death awaited them.

But even setting all that aside, Qinghai was an indispensable strategic stronghold from a military standpoint.

One side had to defend it. The other had to trample it underfoot to get past.

Dark Heaven has the strength to do it. Besides, Qinghai has been overrun before.

Over fifty years ago, the hundred thousand demonic soldiers led by the Heavenly Demon defeated the Kunlun Sect and took Qinghai. That was the beginning of the Great Faction War.

And now, that brutal history of bloodshed was about to repeat itself after all these years.

Qinghai. Qinghai Province…

I stared out the window, my gaze heavy.

Beyond the latticed frame, hundreds of torches swayed in the darkness that had settled without my noticing.

Night had fallen, but everyone in the Jin Family of Taiyuan was still awake.

No, it wouldn’t be just the Jin Family.

I could picture the whole of Murim in the Central Plains—including the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families—boiling like a cauldron over hot coals.

It’s coming. The all-out war we can’t avoid.

The drums of war had been pounding across the land for a long time. But the countless enemies even now crossing the desert toward somewhere in the west weighed on my heart more heavily than ever.

Those who meant to defend, and those who meant to take.

A battle unlike anything we’d faced so far awaited us all in the west. Each side would stake its fate on it.

The fate of this world might be decided by a single battle, soon to come.

Maybe that was why the System had suddenly malfunctioned. Why this absolute law, which had never strayed from its set path no matter what happened, had begun to waver.

Then what had caught me by the ankle when I tried to leave this place for a little while—just a little while?

The System? Or…

Dark Heaven. No—the Lord of Heaven, to be precise.

I couldn't be sure yet, but I could guess one thing.

Far away in the west, somewhere hidden in that pitch-black darkness, an answer to this mystery was waiting.

Or perhaps death.

Damn it.

Nothing ever goes smoothly.

I gave a bitter smile to myself, then spoke to someone waiting beyond the firmly shut door.

"We leave in exactly fifteen minutes."

"As you command."

I heard Hyuk Mujin's footsteps receding after his unusually forceful reply. As I stood, I suddenly sensed something strange and turned around.

Tap. Tap-tap.

Something damp and white drifted into the room on the wind.

I looked at the unwelcome visitor that had arrived months ahead of schedule—the snowflakes slowly piling up—and remembered a line from the Quest window.

The world—and the heavens—are being turned upside down.

I prayed silently that those words, at least, weren't an error.

Because the world as I felt it now—and the sky spilling those white snowflakes—seemed to have finished changing already.

The light in the room was dim.

It was already pitch-black outside, and the wind seeping through the crack in the door made the candle flame flicker precariously.

Yet the man reading the letter in his hand didn't so much as twitch an eyebrow. Years of grueling training since childhood had honed his eyesight enough to distinguish its tiny writing even by a flame that looked ready to go out.

He stared at the letter he'd already read several times. In his eyes, the wavering candlelight reflected part of its message.

Return immediately.

The handwriting was sharp as a blade, and beside it was a familiar official seal.

Guessing who had sent the letter, he muttered softly.

“You haven’t changed, have you?”

His voice echoed hollowly, low and subdued.

The letter wasn’t a request or a favor. It was an order.

It had always been this way. Everyone took it for granted, but he had never grown used to it.

The person who’d written that dry, impersonal command, as though ordering a servant, was his own flesh and blood.

More precisely, the person who had given him that blood.

“…Father.”

The word came after a brief hesitation.

It still felt unfamiliar. As he murmured it, he remembered a rigid, cold childhood with no room for dreams, only purpose—and the stern pair of eyes that had watched him through it.

Creepy as it was, those eyes still seemed to be watching everything he did.

Perhaps that was why he failed to notice someone approaching outside the door.

Thump.

“Ugh!”

A sudden noise overlapped with a cry of pain. Then a sharp shout rang out, breaking the silence.

“You idiot! Height! I told you to mind your height!”

“Taishan not stupid. Namho stupid. You saw it. Why didn’t you dodge?”

“You little punk! Is this because I didn’t give you any sweets?”

The familiar voices reached his ears. Guessing the intruders’ identities, he tossed the letter in his hand into the lamp.

Fwoosh. Crackle.

The paper was less than half the size of his palm and had been treated with oil to keep it dry. It went up in flames at once.

At that moment, the firmly shut door flew open.

Or rather, it was smashed to pieces.

“My lord! Are you ready?”

Bam!

The booming shout came with a shower of splinters. But the man—Sama Pyo—didn’t look the least bit startled. He picked up the travel bag beside him and stood.

“Of course. What about you, Taishan?”

“Taishan ready! Perfect!”

Namho, perched on Taishan’s shoulders, spat out a few pieces of wood.

“Of course it’s perfect. Bring just the jerky he packed back to life and you’d have five cows.”

“That sounds like a reasonable amount to me. Not excessive.”

“…It’s a wonder the Black Dragon Demon Gate hasn’t gone bankrupt. He’s a gluttonous demon through and through.”

Sama Pyo gave a short laugh. He already knew that the old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent, who hadn’t seemed all that pleasant at first, had a warm heart and a fair amount of affection for others.

“More importantly, what were you doing in here alone?”

“I stopped by for a moment. There was something I needed to take care of before we left.”

“Is that so?”

Namho glanced over Sama Pyo’s shoulder, but the letter, soaked through with oil, had already burned away without a trace.

“Then put that fire out before you come out. The weather’s shitty enough without you burning down someone else’s thatched cottage.”

“Oh, I almost forgot.”

Sama Pyo answered mildly and waved a hand, snuffing out the candle. Then, as though nothing had happened, he headed for the doorway.

“Let’s go. Everyone must be waiting.”

Namho watched Sama Pyo’s back with a curious look.

But only for a moment.

Thump.

“Ugh!”

Namho struck his forehead on the eaves again. With a cry, he grabbed Taishan by the hair and yanked.

Chapter 997

Fifteen minutes.

Too short to properly savor even a cup of tea, but plenty of time for the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, myself included, to finish our preparations.

And to prepare a send-off no one else had expected.

Whoooosh. Fwoosh.

Countless torches swayed.

Neither the early darkness nor the snowstorm now whipping fiercely through the air could put out that vast blaze.

Crunch.

Footprints marked the snow-covered ground.

Leaving behind hundreds of people standing like iron towers, each holding a torch in one hand, Jin Wikyung stepped forward alone. Then he suddenly spoke.

“The prodigal son finally came home, only to leave again.”

His voice was stern, as if he were passing judgment on a criminal, but *prodigal son* drew quiet laughter from here and there.

By now, everyone in the Jin Family of Taiyuan knew it. Not just them, but all of Shanxi Province—or rather, the whole world.

Jin Taekyung was no longer the Shame of the Family or a dissolute rogue.

Ever since the day, more than a year ago, when I defeated the traitors—including the Head Elder—and restored peace, I had been their pride and their symbol.

“I never wanted to send you away again.”

I shrugged at Jin Wikyung, who muttered the words with a bitter expression.

“What can I do? Guess it’s fate.”

“What came from the Murim Alliance was information, not an order. If you change your mind, even now, you can stay with the family and leave with everyone else.”

“That sounds nice. But I’ll go ahead and wait for you. I hate being late.”

Jin Wikyung let out a small groan at my polite refusal.

He was practically the Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, so he couldn’t simply leave. He had to keep not only the family members but countless martial artists from Shanxi under control as they moved—and the nomads they had subdued, too.

It was much the same for the Bow Saint and the Embroidered Uniform Guard, who still hadn’t returned after rooting out the Murong Family’s threat.

A massive army and a small advance unit.

It was obvious which would be slower and which would be faster. And that considerable gap in timing might become the flap of a butterfly’s wings somewhere far away and change a great many things.

Of course, knowing that did nothing to ease his worry for his own flesh and blood.

“It will be dangerous. More than ever before.”

At the sight of Jin Wikyung’s worried expression, my journey so far flashed before my eyes.

Dangerous, huh?

Yeah, of course it would be.

But…

“It always has been. Not once has it been any different, and it won’t be from here on out.”

Looking back, there had never been a time when I wasn’t in danger.

There had never been an easy moment, either.

When I first opened my eyes, I was a tadpole. I struggled to survive and became a frog.

I leaped and leaped with all my might until I escaped the well. Beyond it waited a world incomparably wider and more treacherous than the one I’d left behind.

And at every fork in the road that blocked my way, I had always made a choice.

“It’s the road I chose. I don’t know when I’ll be able to stop, but… I have to keep running. All the way to the end.”

Jin Wikyung was silent for a moment at my matter-of-fact answer. Then he let out a quiet laugh.

“You’ve grown up. Before I knew it, you’d grown so much I hardly recognized you.”

Looking at Jin Wikyung, whose imposing build was enough to make me wonder if he had Hebei Peng blood, I smiled back.

“I’m still not as big as you, hyung[3601].”

“Hyung[3602]. That sounds especially good today. Maybe because it’s been so long since you called me that.”

It wasn’t just because I’d spent so long away. I’d simply needed a little more time to truly accept the new family I’d found in this unfamiliar world.

Even if this body’s true owner wasn’t me.

Right. The real owner—the Jin Family’s Third Young Master—is someone else.

The thought weighed on me, but the familiar face that appeared beside Jin Wikyung a moment later washed it away.

“Oh, would you look at that. Isn’t that our family’s second son?”

At my exaggeratedly wide-eyed look, Jin Mukyung shook his head.

[3601] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

[3602] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

“Here we go again.”

“What? Did I say anything wrong? You are the second son.”

“You conveniently left out the ‘hyung’[3603] that’s supposed to come after it.”

“I’ll add it if you want. Beat me first.”

“…You shameless bastard.”

“What, you don’t think you can?”

Jin Mukyung stared at me in disbelief, then gave a short laugh.

“Of course I can. Just wait. I’ll catch up soon.”

“Confidence is good, but don’t expect it to be easy.”

“I know. But you’d better remember one thing, too.”

“What?”

“Until I catch up, don’t let anyone else take you down. Ever.”

“…!”

For a moment, I couldn’t speak. Seeing me blink at him in silence, Jin Mukyung seemed to regret what he’d said. He hesitated, then suddenly extended his fist.

Tap.

His slow but solid punch landed against my chest.

Even with the snowstorm raging all around us, warmth spread through the spot where his fist had touched before drawing away.

“Go ahead. This time, I won’t be late. I promise.”

Maybe he was embarrassed to have shown a side of himself he usually kept hidden. Or maybe some emotion had welled up in him.

Whatever the reason, Jin Mukyung turned away after those words. In the direction he headed, more familiar faces were waiting for me.

Wipeng, who had come to see me off despite his grievous injuries.

Lee Seowol, forcing a smile despite the death of her uncle, Cheol Mubaek—the Tiger of Mount Heng—who had been her staunchest guardian and almost another father to her.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan’s senior members, who had served Jin Wikyung with unwavering loyalty and helped him raise the once-declining family into one of the Five Great Families.

The scouts who had once crossed life and death alongside me. The young brother and sister who had grown so much while I was away from the Jin Family of Taiyuan. And countless family retainers whose faces were more familiar than their names.

Every one of them was looking at me.

[3603] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses to address an older brother or an older man with whom he is close.

As I met each person's eyes, they smiled brightly, nodded quietly, and stamped their feet with such overwhelming emotion that their hearts seemed ready to burst.

Hard and strong. Without anyone having to lead, they stamped the ground, now blanketed in white, and drew their weapons like lightning.

Clang-clang-clang-clang!

Amid hundreds of swaying torches, a dazzling wave of steel lit up everything around us, brighter than the snowstorm pouring down overhead. An aura like wildfire rose and heated the air.

Thud. Thud. Thoom!

The ground shook beneath their vigorous footfalls. My heart, which had gradually settled into a steady rhythm to match them, began to pound. Just then, Jin Wikyung's quiet voice slipped into my ear.

"Do you see it?"

I didn't answer.

No—I couldn't.

I could only listen to Jin Wikyung's voice echoing around me, my chest trembling deep inside.

"You are our pride."

"…!"

"Go. Down the road you chose."

Go forward without hesitation, with all your might.

Hearing the rest of his words swallowed by the fierce snowstorm, I finally moved my feet.

Crunch.

Beneath a roof of countless crossed blades, new footprints began to mark the white snow.

The untimely snowstorm wasn't confined to Shanxi Province.

The young man had remained silent for a long time, even after his expected guest arrived. Watching the snow whip past the window, he suddenly spoke.

"Long ago—very long ago—someone said something like that to me."

Across the rough table, the guest sat with perfect composure despite a full shichen—about two hours—of silence.

"You've made me curious already. Who was it?"

To anyone who didn't know them, it would have seemed a strange sight.

The room's owner was a young man, while his guest looked to be about eighty.

Yet the scar visible beneath the older man's graying hair spoke of a life spent in secrecy. The same was true of the young man opposite him.

"You know the person, too. I can tell you now, if you want."

The casual way he addressed the older man came as naturally as breathing.

The Thousand-Faced Fox, Song Ho, lightly declined the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's offer.

"I'll try to guess after I hear what was said. I prefer figuring things out for myself to being given the answer."

"Wouldn't most people choose the former?"

"As Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, shouldn't I be able to manage at least that much?"

"That's a fair point."

"So, what did this person say to you, Alliance Leader?"

Still gazing out the window, Mae Jonghak answered.

"He told me to protect it. The place where I stood, the convictions I held in my heart, and the world."

"…!"

"I was told to remain here, unchanged, even if that person disappeared one day. Of course, at the time, it sounded like a passing remark, so I didn't think much of it. That's all."

The Thousand-Faced Fox let out a breath he'd been holding.

"I think I know who it was."

"You do?"

"Yes. As it happens, I believe I heard something similar myself."

"That person would be pleased to know it. You didn't take those words lightly. You've kept the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's intelligence network going all this time."

The Thousand-Faced Fox nodded without a word.

He certainly would have been pleased. Maybe he would even have clapped his hands and burst out laughing.

In Song Ho's memories, the Martial God seemed to carry every worry in the world, yet at times he could be as innocent as a child.

"There's something I'd like to ask you."

"Go ahead, Alliance Leader."

The Thousand-Faced Fox tensed without meaning to.

He feared that the Number One Sword Under Heaven, now the new symbol of the Central Plains Murim in the Martial God's place, might waver at the most crucial moment.

But Mae Jonghak's next words swept that fear away at once.

“When this war is over, what are you going to do?”

“Pardon?”

“No, I just started worrying about you. You hardly get paid for all the work you do. Should I give you a raise now? How about doubling your salary?”

“…!”

“Hmm. Or tripling it? Then you wouldn’t have to worry about retirement.”

The Thousand-Faced Fox stared blankly at Mae Jonghak, frozen like a statue. Then he suddenly burst into a hearty laugh.

When he stopped laughing, he answered.

“Don’t worry about my retirement. If I need to, I can always siphon some money off to the side.”

“Oh. So you already have a plan.”

“Of course.”

“But let’s keep this between the two of us. If our friends outside that door find out, we might get some dirty looks. Don’t you think?”

Mae Jonghak stood without waiting for an answer.

A gust of qi swept through the air and threw open the firmly shut door. Beyond it, dozens of people sat around a massive table.

“I’ll say this up front: as long as the amount is reasonable, I’m willing to turn a blind eye to whatever the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion does.”

At the first playful remark from a middle-aged man, Mae Jonghak nodded with satisfaction.

“Clever, as always. You know just what to say and when.”

“You’re too kind.”

“Now then, did you complete your mission safely, Family Head Zhuge?”

The middle-aged man, Zhuge Feng—the Crouching Dragon Guest—waved his tattered feather fan.

“Can you see it?”

“Quite clearly.”

“These are the marks of my suffering. I thought I was going to die.”

“Which means…”

“The Zhuge Clan has completed every task assigned to it.”

Exclamations rose from around the room. Everyone present knew what Zhuge Feng had been assigned to do, and how important it was.

And it meant one thing.

All preparations were complete. A new phase was beginning.

“Well, then. Everyone’s going to be busy from here on out.”

The opening act of an all-out war had begun.

Chapter 998

As Jin Wikyung had already said, the most likely place for a major battle with Dark Heaven was Qinghai, where the Kunlun Sect was located.

It was a strategic foothold the enemy would have to take before advancing into the Central Plains—and one the orthodox Murim would have to defend with their lives.

That was exactly why I could answer Hyuk Mujin's question about how we would get to Qinghai without hesitation.

"We run. Fucking hard."

"I know that much. What I wanted to ask was…"

"Running fucking hard is fine, but how long do we keep it up?"

"Ah, Captain. You know exactly what I'm thinking."

"Keep going."

"…Excuse me?"

"Keep going. All the way."

"Wait, all the way to Qinghai?"

I asked without easing the reins of my galloping horse.

"Otherwise?"

"I think taking the water route would be better. We can travel overland as you said, then take a tributary of the Yangtze from Shaanxi straight to Qinghai. It'd save us about half a day and take a lot less effort."

On the face of it, the suggestion made sense.

Half a day wasn't much, but we'd arrive sooner and conserve our Stamina before an important battle.

Besides, even the Yangtze River Channel League—the river's gangsters, notorious across the country for generations—was part of the Murim Alliance. If we were lucky, we might be able to hijack a swift ship… No, borrow one.

Or at the very least, a Great Nation military vessel.

But I shook my head at once.

"The land route is better."

"Why? Do you get seasick?"

"…"

"Even if you do, try to bear with it. I'll pat your back."

Was this bastard looking down on a Supreme Peak master?

And I wasn't some newly minted Supreme Peak master, either. I'd reached the pinnacle of martial arts and completed Bone Transformation. I was a superhuman among superhumans.

I could ride a Wolmido Disco Pang Pang[3604] and feel perfectly steady. Seasickness?

I stared at Hyuk Mujin in disbelief, momentarily at a loss for words. Just then, a fierce gust of wind swept toward the back of his head.

Whoosh—smack!

"Gah!"

It was the sort of impact that felt satisfying just to hear. Jeok Cheongang, who had expertly smacked the back of Hyuk Mujin's head, clicked his tongue.

He'd found the saddle uncomfortable, so he was traveling by stepping from branch to branch along the trees lining the road.

"You stupid fool. Why do you talk so much? If your superior tells you to do something, you do it."

If anyone but me had smacked Hyuk Mujin on the back of the head, he'd have been glaring daggers. But when that someone was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, it was a different story.

Unable to talk back, Hyuk Mujin rubbed his aching head and glanced around before speaking.

"I was just offering a better suggestion. Why are you doing this to me?"

"A better suggestion? Do you really think so?"

"Wasn't it…?"

"I'll admit it sounded plausible. But you overlooked the most important thing."

Before Hyuk Mujin could answer, Jeok Cheongang's low voice carried through the wind.

"Dark Heaven. Whether those devious bastards are truly targeting Qinghai."

"…!"

"We know nothing for certain yet. No one knows where Dark Heaven's army, said to be marching beyond the desert, is headed. Qinghai isn't the only route into the Central Plains."

I nodded. Jeok Cheongang had the situation exactly right.

There wasn't just one route. There were three, maybe more.

Qinghai, Gansu, and even Tibet, beyond the borderlands and counted among the Outer Lands.

Qinghai was the likeliest main target because of its strategic importance, but an invasion through Gansu or Tibet was entirely possible too.

And besides…

They have a Warp Gate—or rather, a Moving Formation.

The Moving Formation gave the enemy more options, while serving as a painfully sharp dagger aimed at our backs.

[3604] Wolmido Disco Pang Pang is a Korean amusement-park ride with a spinning, bouncing platform.

They could send as many as a thousand people—at least, that was the number we'd confirmed so far—to somewhere in the Central Plains through a Moving Formation. How could we take that lightly?

Of course, there was a way to deal with it.

The Zhuge Clan, renowned as the finest in the world at mechanisms and formations, possessed a formation called the Demon-Sealing Formation. As its name suggested, it could suppress and seal magical power.

When a "rift" had opened at Dongting Lake, the Zhuge Clan had managed to contain it with the Demon-Sealing Formation, led by their Family Head, Zhuge Feng. That was why the incident had been brought to an end without even greater losses.

If they can stop a rift, they should be able to neutralize a Moving Formation, too. I've seen the Demon-Sealing Formation myself, so I know it works. The problem is time and manpower.

The world was vast.

And no one knew how many Moving Formations Dark Heaven had built somewhere in that boundless sea of sand.

We'd found a way to deal with them well over half a year ago, yet several sects near Shanxi Province had still hesitated to send reinforcements, even for a short while. That alone showed how serious the risk was.

Even if just one Moving Formation remained, it would be like a sharp shard of glass, digging deep into the sole of someone walking carelessly across the sand.

That's why we have to travel overland.

Qinghai had been a battlefield whenever foreign invaders came over the centuries. The Murim Alliance would have prepared the best defenses it could.

Those defenses wouldn't be so flimsy that half a day—or even a full day—would make the difference between holding and falling.

Tibet should be reasonably safe, too. Even if the Potala Palace has joined hands with Dark Heaven, the forces stationed in Sichuan should be able to hold out.

The Sichuan Tang Clan, which the Western Heaven Demon Lord had targeted personally, had suffered tremendous losses. But Qingcheng and Emei were still intact.

And some unexpected guests were staying in Sichuan as well.

The Nanman Beast Palace.

Though we'd left in a hurry with a long road ahead, I'd heard news of them from time to time.

The warriors of the tropics had finally left their jungle in an unprecedented mass migration. They'd readily accepted the Murim Alliance's request and were now defending Sichuan.

"The western front will have made preparations to some extent. Except in one place."

I wasn't speaking to Hyuk Mujin alone.

After finishing my train of thought, I suddenly spoke. I looked around at the Fire Dragon Pavilion members riding alongside me, then added quietly,

"Gansu."

"…!"

"…!"

"If Dark Heaven goes against everyone's expectations and targets Gansu, that's where the biggest battle of this war will be fought."

That was no exaggeration.

Dark Heaven had always found ways to catch us off guard.

Thanks to the efforts of countless people, myself included, who'd practically shit ourselves trying to stop them, their schemes had been thwarted time and again. But that didn't mean the Murim Alliance had gained the upper hand in this war.

No. It would be more accurate to say Dark Heaven had been toying with us.

Shutting the stable door after the horse has bolted.

If we'd caught the arsonist before he set fire to the stable, that would have been a victory.

But the stable had burned every time, and countless people had been slaughtered like livestock.

As the person who'd repeatedly run around dousing the stables wherever I went, I was sick and tired of all of it.

So…

This time, we have to stop them. No matter what.

Before another fire started. Before there were more terrible losses.

We had to be cautious, then cautious again. Test the stone bridge before crossing it. I needed to see the situation in Gansu with my own eyes before moving on to Qinghai.

That was the biggest reason I'd chosen the land route over the slightly faster, more comfortable water route.

And this choice should be a lot more reassuring for him, too.

I glanced at one man.

Half a day had passed since we left the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and Sama Pyo still hadn't said a word. He simply held his reins in silence.

He'd always been taciturn, but lately it had grown more pronounced.

No wonder. If Dark Heaven's army is crossing the deserts of Xinjiang right now, his family could be in danger.

Along with the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, the Black Dragon Demon Gate was one of the two powers that divided Gansu Province between them.

As the Black Dragon Demon Gate's Young Sect Leader, Sama Pyo was bound to have a lot on his mind. All the more so after hearing what Jeok Cheongang and I had just said.

But I didn't try to console him.

Comfort was a luxury in a situation like this. When our eyes met, Sama Pyo gave me a slight, silent nod. I looked away and tightened my grip on the reins.

"Hyah!"

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The grassland horses, said to surpass even sweat-blood horses in endurance, galloped on without a trace of fatigue.

Night and day passed once more, and the moon and sun crossed paths overhead.

Three days swept by like the wind. We left Shanxi Province and reached the border between Shaanxi and Gansu.

"Stop. We'll rest here for half a shichen.[3605]"

The man who suddenly spoke, bringing everyone to a halt, appeared to be around sixty. He was slender, with strikingly narrow eyes.

Of course, the several hundred people following him knew appearances didn't tell the whole story.

Just as what they saw with their eyes wasn't all there was, the old man had lived far longer than he looked. Only his formidable martial prowess could account for it.

Great age and formidable skill.

Of everyone present, only one person could refuse an order from a man who possessed both.

"A rest, out of nowhere? What on earth do you mean, Eldest Senior Brother?"

A half-white-haired Daoist in a clean robe hurried over, looking confused. The old man answered without a care.

"This old body of mine is giving me trouble. I can't go any farther, so I thought we'd rest for half a shichen. Is there a problem?"

"Eldest Senior Brother!"

"Lower your voice, Junior Brother Sect Leader. How can you be so rude to Eldest Senior Brother?"

[3605] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Someone else had cut in. The graying Daoist turned toward the reproachful voice and sighed.

“Why are you doing this too, Senior Brother? It’s been two days since we left the main sect, and we still haven’t reached Gansu. You both know that…”

“Enough.”

The man he’d called Senior Brother—an old Daoist with a luxuriant white beard that made him look like an immortal—raised a hand to cut him off.

“What can we do? Our bodies have grown weak. There’s a limit to how far we can travel. Eldest Senior Brother and I are disappointed in you, Junior Brother Sect Leader.”

“What do you mean?”

“After spending so long recuperating, your two Senior Brothers have only just become able to get around again. Why must you rush us?”

The graying Daoist’s lips moved as if he wanted to say something, but no words came. He turned away.

Even if he had spoken his mind, the outcome would probably have been much the same.

At that very moment, pounding hooves rang through the deserted forest.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Several grassland horses burst through the rising cloud of dust. They spotted the group halted in the middle of the forest path and began to slow.

More precisely, they slowed when they saw the flag rising above the group.

The Great Zhongnan Sect.

From atop his panting grassland horse, the young man riding in front read the characters embroidered in a single flowing stroke and muttered under his breath,

“I think there’s a typo…”

Chapter 999

When I first started working as a Hunter, the veterans had a saying they repeated all the time: you never knew when or where you might cross paths with someone again. So you had to be careful and flexible about making or breaking ties, or you'd have trouble later.

Looking back, I can't think of a more useful piece of advice.

There was just one problem. Advice like that didn't mean a damn thing to a guy like me.

"I think there's a typo…"

The Great Zhongnan Sect.

The words slipped out the moment I read the four characters embroidered on the ornate silk. The nearest Daoist frowned.

"Daoist friend, what did you just say?"

"Oh, nothing. Talking to myself."

"Talking to yourself?"

"Yeah."

"That's rather familiar of you."

"Yeah, sir."

The middle-aged Daoist stared at me, momentarily dumbfounded. He drew a breath before he managed to speak.

"What are you playing at?"

"You called me a friend, so I talked to you like one. Besides, you started speaking casually to me first."

"You look to be a fellow martial artist, but you're much younger than I am. You have quite a mouth on you."

"I can get away with it. I'm young, but in martial seniority I'm an old man."

"What… did you say?"

At that point, it was only natural for him to sense something was amiss. My answer had thrown him off, and an uneasy murmur spread among the Zhongnan Sect disciples watching me and the Fire Dragon Pavilion members who'd appeared so suddenly.

"It's true."

At the sound of a low voice, the crowd parted to either side. I smiled warmly at the familiar faces beyond them.

"It's been a while. Both of you."

Neither returned my greeting. The two old Daoists had stopped abruptly three

jang[3606] away.

“May your health be… uh… what comes after that?”

Hyuk Mujin answered without hesitation.

“Split in two.”

“May your health be split in two. That sounds a little off. Are you sure?”

“No. I don’t really know either. I just said the first thing that came to mind.”

“Are you insane? Now I’m even more confused.”

“I’m sorry.”

“Whatever. Anybody know it?”

Ju Hwaran shot up a hand.

“May you be healthy in every way. May your health be sound in every respect.”

“Oh. As expected of Young Lady Ju. Ten points to the Griffin Yongbong Escort Bureau.”

“Hehe.”

She smiled bashfully, though she had no idea what I meant. I gave her a thumbs-up, then respectfully clasped my hands toward the two old Daoists.

“Anyway. Have you both been split in two?”

“…!”

“…!”

The mood turned as cold as if someone had dumped a bucket of water over us.

I belatedly realized I’d said it wrong and let out a deep sigh. Depending on how they took it, they might misunderstand, but it really was a slip of the tongue.

“Damn it, I got mixed up. Hyuk Mujin.”

“Yes?”

“Get down and put your head on the ground.”

“Ah, yes.”

As Hyuk Mujin performed the remarkable feat of putting his head down while seated in the saddle, one of the old Daoists finally spoke.

“You haven’t changed. Still as brazen as ever.”

He was the first of the two to speak, an old Daoist with a thick snow-white beard. It hung down to his navel, making him look like an immortal who’d descended to the mortal world. But I already knew better.

Hwangbo Eom, the Taeeul Merciless Sword, was about as far from an immortal as a man could get.

Not even close. If he were half as good inside as he looked, he never would’ve pulled a stunt that shameless.

[3606] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft); three jang are about 9.09 meters (29.8 ft).

It might be unfortunate for him and the Zhongnan Sect, but I didn't have the memory of a goldfish.

They'd entrusted Ju Hwaran's Yongbong Escort Bureau with transporting their priceless Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng, then secretly stolen it back and demanded compensation. It was an insurance scam meant to swallow the Bureau whole. I'd remember it for the rest of my life.

Of course, the old man beside Hwangbo Eom, darting his eyes this way and that, had a colorful record of his own.

"Looking for someone?"

"…What?"

"I asked if you were looking for someone, Great Hero Song Il."

The Roaring Fury Swordsman's eyebrows twitched at the amusement in my voice.

A year and several months ago, Song Il had tried to overturn the Jin Family of Taiyuan's banquet, backed by his Supreme Peak martial prowess and his illustrious position as a Zhongnan Sect Elder. He'd nearly ended up the guest of honor at a funeral instead.

Now he was anxiously scanning our group, searching for one person: a man who, Zhongnan Sect or not, wouldn't think twice about slapping someone across the face and kicking them in the shins for good measure if the mood took him.

I spoke gently.

"You can relax. The person you're looking for isn't here."

"…!"

"Oh, did I get it wrong? Were you looking for someone else?"

Song Il glared at me in silence before squeezing out his answer.

"You dare—"

"Dare to what?"

That wasn't me.

Jeok Cheongang dropped out of empty air, and Song Il's eyes went wide.

"H-How can you be here?"

"What? 'You'?"

"N-No, that's not what I meant."

Song Il stammered and backed away.

A bristly crop of red hair had grown over Jeok Cheongang's once-smooth scalp, and his face now looked middle-aged. Word that he'd broken through to another great realm and regained his youth had spread far and wide. The Zhongnan Sect was no exception.

"F-Fire King Jeok Cheongang…!"

Someone blurted out the name, and shock swept through the crowd. They were seeing the Fire King himself for the first time—and realizing that the young

upstart who'd appeared out of nowhere was the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

Song Il looked between Jeok Cheongang and me as though he couldn't believe his eyes. I spread my arms wide.

"Ta-da! I lied!"

"…!"

"What do you think? Surprised?"

We hadn't seen each other in ages. A little surprise was only fair.

From the way he sucked in a breath and started trembling, I'd definitely surprised him. He looked less startled than on the verge of a fit, though.

Fortunately for Song Il, someone intervened before he keeled over.

"This humble Gong of the Zhongnan Sect pays his respects to Great Hero Jeok."

A graying Daoist with a goatee of awkward, in-between length clasped his hands respectfully despite his haste. At the sight of the Zhongnan Sect Leader, Jeok Cheongang clicked his tongue, disappointed that he couldn't keep tormenting Song Il.

"Well, it's been a while. What was your name again? Gong Piljung?"

"Not Piljung. Iljung. I'm Gong Iljung, Great Hero Jeok."

"Ah, yes. I remember now. Wind-and-Cloud War God Gong Iljung."

"…Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord."

"Good grief. I keep getting my words mixed up today. Sorry about that, Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord Gong Piljung."

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord looked at me, all the fight gone out of him. His half-resigned eyes held a question he desperately wanted answered.

Is he doing this to mess with me on purpose?

Eyes can be an excellent way to communicate. I answered with mine.

No. He's just like that.

That wasn't empty reassurance. Honestly, neither Jeok Cheongang nor I had any particular grudge against Gong Iljung.

We had plenty against his Senior Brothers, Song Il and Hwangbo Eom. But we'd only crossed paths with Gong Iljung a couple of times, at the Star-Array Grand Banquet and the founding of the Murim Alliance. We had no reason to hold anything against him.

Jeok Cheongang looked ready to punch Song Il, yet he was still addressing Gong Iljung with a measure of courtesy. That said enough.

Besides, people don't have much bad to say about the Zhongnan Sect Leader.

Feeling a little sorry that he'd caught some of the insult unintentionally, I shook my head. Gong Iljung seemed to relax.

"I'm surprised. I didn't expect to see you here again."

"Likewise."

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation, then looked over the Zhongnan Sect Disciples filling the forest path and added,

"I thought you'd be in Gansu or Qinghai by now."

"…"

"Shaanxi's right next door. Why are you sprawled out resting here?"

Now that was a direct hit. Gong Iljung flushed.

"W-Well…"

He couldn't bring himself to finish, but his eyes shifted toward the answer.

Song Il and Hwangbo Eom watched us with grim faces. I could piece together most of what had happened.

They'd dug in their heels and dared anyone to do something about it.

For some reason, those old bastards seemed to have held the whole Zhongnan Sect back. I was almost certain of it, especially since something similar had happened recently.

Come to think of it, those two were the only ones who didn't show up.

When the bloodshed erupted in Shanxi Province, the Hebei Peng Family, Huashan, and even Murim Alliance Headquarters sent reinforcements. Their timely arrival helped us bring the fighting to a complete end.

The Zhongnan Sect?

Strictly speaking, they came.

A day after the battle was over.

Of course, sending reinforcements meant taking some risk, and I was grateful for that much. But it still left a bad taste in my mouth.

They said they'd sent a thousand troops. Three hundred reached Shanxi Province, more than half of them useless nobodies. And even that lot was late.

Put all three together, and the feeling of *this is fucking bullshit* was bound to rise from deep in my gut. Add the sight of two faces I never wanted to see again, and my mouth moved on its own.

"Well, it happens. Making the journey at all in your condition is a fine display of righteous spirit."

Song Il and Hwangbo Eom frowned as the remark found its marks.

"You brat! I told you to stop running your mouth!"

Jeok Cheongang's stern rebuke was directed at me. He went on without pause.

"Just making it this far while pissing blood all the way here makes you heroes! These great seniors of the Murim are only now beginning to act their age after all this time. How can you speak to them so rudely?"

"…!"

"…!"

“What have they done that’s so wrong? Did they throw their weight around to force a weaker sect to close its doors? Or steal a Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng and try to swallow an innocent Escort Bureau whole?”

Each word from the merciless Tongue King cut to the bone. Gong Iljung struggled to get his voice out.

“G-Great Hero Jeok. Please, for my sake and my Master’s…”

“All right. I’ll stop here.”

“Thank you.”

“No need to thank me, Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord Gong Piljung.”

“…”

Vicious. Absolutely vicious.

Chapter 1000

If the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword had shown even a hint of displeasure at that moment—or if they'd been unable to keep their itching hands still and started fiddling with their sword hilts—something serious might have happened.

Me aside, Jeok Cheongang was not the sort of man to stand by and let that happen.

And the Zhongnan Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord Gong Pil—no, Gong Iljung—shared that concern.

—Tell me, Friend Jin. Are you just going to watch?

A low voice reached my ear through Sound Transmission.

Jeok Cheongang's brow twitched as he sensed the sound waves. At that very moment, someone spoke.

"What must we do… to earn your forgiveness?"

Everyone's eyes widened, mine included.

Why?

Simple.

Someone we never expected had said something we never expected to hear.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il.

That old Daoist, whose pride bordered on arrogance, had opened his tightly sealed lips and asked for forgiveness.

And the "we" he'd used included someone else.

"I've thought about it countless times over the past few months. About the wrongs I committed, and what came of them."

The Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom.

He and the Roaring Fury Swordsman were the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's only two Senior Brothers and the most senior members of the Zhongnan Sect. Hwangbo Eom looked at me as he continued.

"It was my fault. I can't deny that."

His gaze sank. His voice trembled.

I watched him in silence, then suddenly spoke.

"Did you mean what you just said?"

"Do you doubt my sincerity?"

"Of course not."

I swallowed hard and added, "I believe you. At the same time, I'll put the unpleasant memories of the past behind me. I can't say I was blameless in the trouble that happened that day, either."

Everyone's eyes widened at my calm reply. Those who knew me well were probably the most surprised.

Even to me, the voice coming out of my mouth sounded like someone else's.

But another voice slipped out at the same time, and that one was different.

It was what I truly thought, but couldn't say aloud in front of everyone.

—I don't believe you. No, I *won't* believe you.

—…!

—If Great Hero Hwangbo truly regretted what he did, I can't explain what we saw just a moment ago. I think you both know what I mean.

I sent the Sound Transmission and looked calmly at the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

Only moments had passed since they'd clenched their teeth and trembled with their fists balled tight. That wasn't long enough to forget.

And yet it must have been a long, painful road for them to stand here on their own two feet.

There's still resentment. Of course there is.

I wasn't asking them to erase it completely.

People don't change easily.

Not me. Not them.

But now was the time to set aside the bad blood between us and move forward. Everyone knew that.

—What answer do you want from us?

—The truth. What you genuinely think—not something meant to be shown or said for someone else's benefit.

—…!

—You don't have to understand each other. But you have to acknowledge your own feelings and accept the distance between you before you can join hands. I think you both know that already.

A silence that lasted too long would invite suspicion.

In the brief hush, the two old Daoists looked at each other, then clasped their hands toward us.

"I, Song Il, bow my head and apologize for the disrespect I showed the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"Please forgive me for forgetting my duty as a Daoist and putting the Yongbong Escort Bureau in danger. I promise to apologize again and do everything I can to compensate you."

The Roaring Fury Swordsman bowed to me. The Taeeul Merciless Sword bowed to Ju Hwaran.

The Zhongnan Sect Disciples who witnessed it reacted in all sorts of ways.

Some bit their lips in frustration. Some wore faint smiles. Others couldn't bear to watch their elders apologize to outsiders, so they closed their eyes as if they hadn't seen it or looked away.

But most of them probably didn't notice that those stiff bows, made by men who had gone so long without bending to anyone, hid the slight movement of their lips.

—Yes, you're right. Bad blood doesn't disappear so easily once it's there. And I know that you, who say so, aren't much different from us.

—But now is the time to gather our strength and face our great enemy. That is why we, as members of the great Zhongnan Sect and respected masters of the Murim, will fight for the world. Nothing more.

Their Sound Transmissions reached both my ears at once.

If those were their genuine feelings, I had no reason to refuse.

Step.

For the first time since we'd encountered the Zhongnan Sect, I dismounted. Ju Hwaran followed my cue and set her feet on the ground.

Then?

We clasped our hands toward the two old Daoists, so respectfully that no one could have found fault with it.

Jeok Cheongang watched me in silence with a curious smile, then shrugged at the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord.

"Better to keep things friendly. Right, Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord Gong Iljung?"

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had looked like he'd just aged ten years. Now, as the situation came to a gentle close, he let out a sigh.

"Piljung. I've told you several times already, it's Gong Piljung…"

"Gong Piljung? Wasn't it Gong Iljung?"

"…?"

"…?"

"Ah."

"What's the problem?"

Only then did the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord realize something was off. He shook his head as if he'd been bewitched.

The tense atmosphere had lasted only a little while at the start.

Once things had settled, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord—briefly confused by Jeok Cheongang's dazzling name-changing technique—was the first to speak.

"May I ask where you're headed?"

Jeok Cheongang answered flatly.

“Of course not.”

“Pardon?”

“Ask someone else. I’m only here as a guest. Someone else is in the presiding chair.”

Who was Jeok Cheongang? The Fire King himself.

He was also the head of the Five Kings Hall, newly established alongside the Murim Alliance. The idea that he was merely a guest was ridiculous.

But the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord nodded without argument and came over to me.

If Jeok Cheongang said so, then that was how it was. If he said otherwise, then it wasn’t.

As the leader of a great sect like the Zhongnan Sect, he took Jeok Cheongang’s answer to mean that his Master wanted to give his Disciple the authority to speak.

I saw it differently, of course.

“Great Hero Jeok cares for you a great deal.”

“He must have found you pretty annoying.”

“…?”

“He doesn’t like it when people he isn’t close to keep talking to him. Give him some space for the next half day or so.”

“…!”

“I’m telling you so you don’t misunderstand. I’m not joking.”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord looked back and forth between me and Jeok Cheongang as if he couldn’t believe what he was hearing. He gave an awkward reply.

“Thank you for the kind advice.”

“Don’t mention it.”

“And as Sect Leader, I can’t say this in public, but I’m grateful to you for the other matter, too.”

The other matter.

It was vague, but I had no trouble understanding him.

He was thanking me, in his own way, for settling things peacefully with his two Senior Brothers.

“You don’t have to thank me. Honestly… they were the ones who brought it up, and that helped resolve things.”

What would have happened if even the slightest killing intent had slipped from the Roaring Fury Swordsman or the Taeeul Merciless Sword?

Given the situation, it probably wouldn’t have turned into a massive bloodbath. But neither Jeok Cheongang nor I would have stood by and done nothing.

No matter how close Dark Heaven's blade was to our throats, we couldn't ignore a dagger coming at us from behind.

"Well, thanks to them, things are more or less settled for now. That's a relief."

"Mm. It surprised me, too. Though I doubt my Senior Brothers have entirely let go of their feelings."

I looked at him in surprise. The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord gave a faint, wry laugh.

"What, did you think I wouldn't know?"

"No. I just…"

"I joined Zhongnan when I was twelve. We served the same Master, and we've spent well over fifty years together. I know my Senior Brothers better than anyone. But as their Junior Brother and as Sect Leader, I should say no more."

From the sound of it, he'd cleaned up the messes his Senior Brothers made more than once.

I decided this was the time to ask him directly.

"Is that why the reinforcements never really came?"

"…That's a sharp question."

"I just want to know what happened. I'm not accusing you."

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord let out a faint sigh under my unwavering gaze.

"It wasn't any one person's fault. Even I couldn't bring myself to send a large portion of our sect's main force."

"Meaning?"

"I made that decision out of concern for Zhongnan's safety. If it upset you and the Jin Family of Taiyuan, there was nothing to be done."

Sometimes a direct, plain answer is the right one.

Like now.

I thought for a moment, then quietly nodded.

"What does that mean?"

"I mean I understand. Completely."

"Then…"

"It would be ridiculous to tell people who are helping us exactly how they should help. We had enough reinforcements without Zhongnan. I only wanted to know why."

"I see. Then is that enough?"

"Of course."

I didn't bother adding *for now*.

Nor did I bring up the bad blood between the Zhongnan Sect and the Nanman Beast Palace from the Great Faction War.

For the moment, this was the best we could do.

Now was the time to look at the forest, not the branches. There was nothing to gain from falling out with the Zhongnan Sect.

We need Zhongnan's strength to face Dark Heaven's army threatening the west.

There were three Supreme Peak masters here alone.

And even at a glance, the Zhongnan Sect Disciples they led were the elite of the main sect.

That meant they, too, intended to give their all in the great battle to come.

Remembering the bad blood of the past without dwelling on it was the right choice.

I hoped that choice would lead everyone in a better direction.

That was the only way we could send the Fire Dragon Pavilion members back home in one piece after a short rest—one they were getting up from now, after days of marching without respite.

Actually, two of them are already on their way home.

I was lost in thought, looking at Sama Pyo and Taishan, when the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord spoke.

"So, where are you headed? Qinghai, like Huashan, who passed us earlier? Or…"

"Gansu. We're going to Gansu."

I'd been about to ask where the Zhongnan Sect was headed, but realized I didn't need to.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's face had brightened considerably. That told me they were going the same way we were.

Chapter 1001

We ended up traveling with the Zhongnan Sect almost before I knew it.

Their Sect Leader, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, proposed it, and while I was still thinking it over, Jeok Cheongang cut in and accepted.

“Traveling together? That wouldn’t be a bad idea.”

“Old—no, Master.”

“What are you standing around for? Get your subordinates ready. And you too, Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord—start by kicking those lazy disciples of yours in the ass.”

Just like that, the preparations were over.

Our party, now a little over a thousand if I rounded generously, set off toward Gansu. The Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword came along too, neither looking pleased about it.

“Those two have looked downright miserable for a while now. If we’d met them exactly six months earlier, I’d have punched them in the jaw first thing.”

Jeok Cheongang smacked his lips. I clicked my tongue.

“If you didn’t want to look at them, you shouldn’t have accepted.”

“Is that why your lips are sticking out three inches?”

“Who says my lips are sticking out?”

“Correction. They’re sticking out four inches now.”

I shook my head at his teasing.

We’d taken the rear, a good thirty jang[3607] behind the Zhongnan Sect. Being far enough away to talk openly was about the only advantage I could see.

“Yes, I’m annoyed. Happy?”

“I can never quite figure you out. Why make up with them if it was only for show?”

Only for show.

I couldn’t have put it better myself.

I’d already guessed Jeok Cheongang had heard everything we’d said through Sound Transmission, so I answered without surprise.

“Well, obviously…”

“Because you need to?”

“Yes.”

“You make peace because you need to, and smile as if the old grudges are behind you… You’ve grown up.”

There was something odd about his tone.

[3607] A jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty jang is about 91 m (298 ft).

I couldn’t tell whether that was praise or a rebuke. When I stared at him without answering, he gave a quiet laugh.

“Don’t overthink it. I’m glad to see you’ve grown, whichever direction it may be in.”

“Do you think it might be the wrong direction?”

“Who knows? What matters is the outcome.”

“Don’t people usually say the process matters just as much? Sometimes more?”

“The first is what narrow-minded fools say. The second is bullshit from people who’ve thoroughly botched the outcome.”

Jeok Cheongang answered with cutting certainty, then went on.

“If I thought you’d done wrong, I’d have given you a proper scolding. So far, though, you haven’t done too badly. Besides, driving those lazy bastards all the way to Gansu like cattle has its appeal.”

He wasn’t wrong. Even now, the Zhongnan Sect Disciples were running their asses off, thanks to the declaration Jeok Cheongang had made before we set out and he’d claimed the rear for himself.

“From now until we reach Gansu, anyone who falls even a little behind or tries to slack off gets a private meeting with this old man.”

A private lesson with an elder who’d reached a distant realm would be a fortuitous encounter anyone would pray for—unless the teacher was the Fire King. In that case, there was a good chance you’d become a dead man.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

Have you ever seen hyenas racing for their lives along a mountainside? Or rather, Zhongnan Sect Disciples?

I have.

Jeok Cheongang watched them sprint with every last bit of strength they had, looking thoroughly satisfied. Then he suddenly kicked off the ground.

Boom! Whoooosh!

A sharp boom rang out. His figure shot forward, leaving an afterimage behind.

Jeok Cheongang’s afterimage seemed to remain behind as he rapidly closed in. The Zhongnan Sect Disciples sucked in their breath, and panicked shouts rang out among them.

“Run!”

“If he catches us, we’re finished!”

“S-Senior Brother, I can’t go on. Don’t worry about this useless Junior Brother. Just go…”

“No! Don’t give up! You can make it!”

“…”

My thoughts on the scene were brief.

You're all making a damn spectacle of yourselves.

"Anyone would think Dark Heaven had shown up or someth—huh?"

I was clicking my tongue at the Zhongnan Sect Disciples fleeing like locusts from a wildfire when I spotted something and narrowed my eyes.

Then I understood why Jeok Cheongang had suddenly sped ahead.

What's that?

We had come out of the narrow mountain path, and a hill opened up the view ahead. In the distance stood a small village, its hundred or so thatched cottages huddled together. A crowd had gathered around it.

There had to be several hundred people.

Hyuk Mujin spotted the crowd at the village entrance a moment after I did. His eyes widened.

"Captain. Could that be…"

I could hear the urgency in his voice. Before he could finish, I said, "Don't panic. They don't look like enemies."

"Huh? Then…"

"They're all civilians."

I thought for a moment and added, "At least, from what I can see."

I wasn't completely sure. Judging by our route, we were somewhere on the border between Shaanxi and Gansu. Dark Heaven had the dark art known as the Moving Formation, so running into its people disguised as civilians here wouldn't be all that surprising.

They'd already disguised themselves as government troops in Sichuan once.

If something had happened in Gansu, word would've reached us by now. So what are that many people doing in a tiny mountain village? Is Dark Heaven preparing an ambush with a Moving Formation?

One question led to another.

Then, all of a sudden, I heard a chilling sound.

Shing.

At the sudden sound of a blade being drawn, I turned. Sama Pyo had drawn the Black Dragon Saber, the weapon that shared its name with his sobriquet.

"Whoever they are, it won't hurt to be prepared. Wouldn't you agree, Pavilion Master?"

His voice was calm, but his eyes were dark and intent. The closer we'd come to Gansu, the more somber Sama Pyo had grown.

I nodded and urged my horse on.

Thud, thud, thud, thud!

My grassland horse's hooves pounded the ground.

I didn't know who the people ahead of us were, but I was sure of one thing.

Even if Dark Heaven prepared an ambush, all we have to do is trample them and keep going.

We might be riding into a fierce battle. My heartbeat didn't change.

I'd grown far too strong to be stopped in a mountain valley like this.

In the end, the disaster I'd feared never happened.

No. Let me correct that.

It never happened to our side.

"They're here! Those bastards are here!"

"Aaaah!"

"E-Everyone, get out of the way!"

The shouts and screams were only natural. Close to a thousand suspicious people had come pouring over the steep hill like water through a broken embankment, and some already had blades in their hands.

To the hundreds gathered at the little village entrance, it must have looked like a catastrophe.

Their terror was impossible to fake. The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, racing at the front alongside Jeok Cheongang, shouted like thunder.

"Enough! Everyone, stop!"

Whoosh!

It was an order from the Sect Leader himself. His voice carried internal energy, and the Zhongnan Sect Disciples quickly slowed to a halt.

But there are always exceptions.

Whoosh.

A faint sound of air being cut, distinct from the rest.

Two figures kept shooting forward like the wind, ignoring the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's command. I'd been slowing with the Zhongnan Sect Disciples, but at the sight of their backs, I clicked my tongue to myself.

Yeah. I had a feeling they'd do that.

Old habits die hard.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

Sect Leader or not, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord was their Junior Brother. Those two old dogs ignored his order and kept going.

I kicked off the ground after them.

Whoosh!

[3608] A jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Thirty jang is about 91 m (298 ft).

A gale wrapped around me as I crossed dozens of jang[3608] in an instant. The two old Daoists drew closer. So did the civilians' screams.

Then a voice reached every ear, including mine.

"Stop."

"…!"

"…!"

It was quiet—not a forceful shout, and it carried no particular internal energy.

One word was enough to stop the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword in their tracks. More important than the word itself was the man who'd said it.

"Are you deaf? Those ears don't seem much use. Want me to rip one off?"

The Roaring Fury Swordsman had stopped only a few steps away from a civilian who stood frozen with his eyes squeezed shut. His face stiff, he began to speak.

"Senior, I was only trying to make sure…"

"Answer the question. Should I rip it off or not?"

"…"

"I thought you were just deaf, but now it seems your mouth's sealed shut too. Fine. You answer for your ailing Senior Brother."

Fire flickered in Jeok Cheongang's eyes. The Taeeul Merciless Sword met his gaze and bowed his head slightly.

"I only wanted to confirm who they were. I had no other intention. If my rash action upset you, Great Hero Jeok…"

"You didn't upset me. You just made an even bigger mess."

"I apologize."

"At least one of you has a working mouth."

Jeok Cheongang frowned at him and let out a small sigh.

"Save your apologies for the people you scared half to death."

He was right. Unlike the few who'd been quick enough to flee, the civilians still standing there were trembling. One man who looked somewhat less shaken than the others hurriedly waved his hands.

"Oh, it's all right, sir. It happened so suddenly that we were startled, but…"

He glanced at the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword, letting the sentence trail off, then looked at Jeok Cheongang and me.

"Y-You're from the Murim Alliance, aren't you? The heroes?"

Calling ourselves heroes after the commotion we'd caused was embarrassing, but I nodded. The man relaxed, and so did the civilians around him.

"Good grief. That took ten years off my life."

"The Murim Alliance… Isn't that the group fighting those wicked foreign invaders?"

“That’s right. There’s been a little misunderstanding.”

“Damn it. I thought we were going to die.”

Sighs of relief rose all around us. The first man’s face brightened, and he spoke again.

“To think you’re the Murim Alliance heroes we’ve heard so much about! What a relief. When we saw a bunch of strange fellows coming, we thought you were *them*… Oh, listen to me. Calling you strange fellows!”

He hurriedly clapped a hand over his mouth, but neither Jeok Cheongang nor I cared about the slip. We had looked strange enough, and he’d said something far more important.

“Who did you think they were?”

The man answered without hesitation.

“Who else? That vicious gang of mounted bandits.”

What?

Chapter 1002

"Who else would it be? Those vicious mounted bandits."

The moment I heard the man's answer, Jeok Cheongang and I looked at each other.

And for good reason. Mounted bandits were the last people I'd expected to hear about now.

Mounted bandits.

Just what the name said: bandits on horseback.

Just as the Yangtze River Channel League had strongholds along every branch of the Yangtze, and the Green Forest Alliance had mountain strongholds on every mountainside with a road, mounted bandits could be found wherever broad plateaus and plains stretched out.

Pung Yang's Red Wind Band had been one of them.

The vast northern Great Steppe wasn't home to nomads alone.

It was a refuge for all kinds of people who'd crossed the Great Wall—and their only sanctuary.

For those who could never return to the lives they'd left behind, there were two choices.

Eat or be eaten.

Naturally, most chose the former.

It was a hundred, a thousand times better to survive as a predator than become prey.

Pung Yang had probably followed the same path.

I had no idea how he'd obtained a Temporary Strength Pill or learned demonic martial arts worthy of being called a secret technique, but he'd made quite a name for himself as a predator.

He'd even had the nerve to lead hundreds of subordinates across the Great Wall.

In the end, though, Pung Yang and the Red Wind Band had met their end at the Mount Heng Sword Sect.

However large they grew, they were still bandits.

Even in Shanxi Province, dismissed as a backwater compared with the Central Plains, there were clear limits to what a band of mounted bandits could do.

And now mounted bandits are hanging around here? Right on the border between Gansu and Shaanxi?

Even the craziest bastards knew to check whether they had somewhere to lie down before stretching out their legs.

With the Kongtong Sect and the Black Dragon Demon Gate standing firm in Gansu, and Huashan and the Zhongnan Sect in Shaanxi, it made no sense for mounted bandits to swagger around here.

Something's going on. It has to be.

Jeok Cheongang must have been thinking the same thing.

He was frowning in thought, so I spoke to the man.

"Could you tell us more about them?"

"You mean the mounted bandits?"

"Yes. Their exact location and numbers, if you know them. If not, even a rumor would help."

The man had been blinking at us in silence, apparently picking up on the serious mood. Then he spoke.

"How much will you pay?"

"What?"

"Four silver nyang[3609]. That should be enough."

"…?"

What was this guy's deal all of a sudden?

Before I could answer, the man scratched his cheek awkwardly.

Or rather, he pretended to scratch it while tracing letters on his cheek.

The name of someone who wasn't here—but whom I could never forget.

Wol…hwa. Wait. Wolhwa?

I finally understood. My mouth fell open as the man—or rather, the Lower District Sect member—winked at me.

"You seem to be in a hurry. Why don't we talk on the way?"

"…!"

I'd almost forgotten.

The Lower District Sect's eyes and ears were everywhere.

I let out a quiet laugh at his shameless act, as though nothing had happened, then called out.

"Mujin."

Hyuk Mujin came hurrying over and answered at once.

"Yes, Captain. What do you need?"

"Give this gentleman four silver nyang[3610]—no, ten. And provide him with a horse."

I was turning away after delivering the order when Hyuk Mujin's muttering reached my ears.

"You could at least toss me a money pouch before saying that. And if you give him a horse, what am I supposed to ride?"

"…Ahem."

[3609] Nyang is a traditional unit used to reckon silver currency. Its value varied by period and place.

[3610] Nyang is a traditional unit used to reckon silver currency. Its value varied by period and place.

“See? You heard me, but you’re pretending you didn’t. I’m so fed up, I ought to just quit—”

“Ahem!”

“Uh, what is it? Did you have another order for me?”

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes went wide and innocent, as if he’d never said a thing. I gave him a cold look and tossed him the money pouch I’d just taken out of my Inventory.

“Oh my, you really shouldn’t have. You could just deduct whatever you spend from my monthly pay, and if it’s not enough, I could ask my family for more. Or beg.”

“I’m… sorry.”

“What do you have to apologize for, Captain? Even if the pillars of the Hyuk Family Textile Shop start shaking, that’s my problem. Right?”

“I get it. Just stop already. That should cover it, right?”

“What about the horse?”

“…!”

“If you give away the horse too, what am I supposed to ride? Are my dead ancestors going to carry me?”

Out of answers, I quietly turned my head toward a nearby Zhongnan Sect Disciple.

More specifically, toward the fine horse he was riding.

After that whirlwind of shakedowns, we got an outcome everyone could be satisfied with and set off toward Gansu Province again.

Of course, one Zhongnan Sect Disciple had to climb down from his comfortable saddle and travel on his own two sturdy legs. But that wasn’t my problem.

What mattered to me was the information the Lower District Sect member had.

“You should all stay around here for the time being. No—better not stay anywhere near here. Head toward Shaanxi. Those vicious mounted bandits could attack at any moment.”

The Lower District Sect member repeated his warnings to the civilians who remained, then mounted his horse. The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord left a dozen or so Disciples behind to lead them safely to Shaanxi if danger arose.

As soon as we set off, the Lower District Sect member’s first words were enough to leave everyone feeling as if they’d been smacked in the back of the head.

“To be honest, there are no mounted bandits.”

“…?”

“…?”

After a brief silence, Hyuk Mujin fingered the hilt of the sword at his waist.

“Ten silver nyang[3611]. Spit it back out while I’m still asking nicely.”

“Enough! Hold your tongue! Threatening an ally—how are you any different from those demonic, heterodox villains?”

Jeok Cheongang sternly rebuked Hyuk Mujin, then turned to the frightened Lower District Sect member and spoke with unusual kindness.

“Don’t mind that fool. Go on. Ten silver nyang[3612] is a small price to pay for your fare to the afterlife.”

“…”

God, he’s terrifying.

Just from listening to them, you’d think we were the Demonic Path Alliance, not the Murim Alliance.

The Lower District Sect member, who didn’t seem to have a shred of internal energy, had gone pale under the pressure. He stammered out an explanation.

“To be precise, there were mounted bandits, but they’ve disappeared.”

“Oh? They were there, and now they’re gone.”

Jeok Cheongang let out an appreciative sound and smiled kindly.

“That makes perfect sense, given the situation. You’ll soon disappear from this world, too.”

“Eek!”

“I’ll take back nine silver nyang[3613]. You can keep one for the trip.”

“Gah!”

“Enough, all of you!”

Only after I stepped in did tempers, boiling like a cauldron over a charcoal fire, finally settle down. The poor Lower District Sect member hurriedly explained the details.

“So the mounted bandits in Ningxia Province really have started acting strangely?”

“Y-Yes.”

“Then all those people gathered in the village…”

“I deliberately spread an exaggerated rumor. Trouble is about to break out in the western region, so we wanted to keep the civilians from getting caught up in it as much as possible.”

“Dark Heaven is far away, but the mounted bandits are close?”

“Exactly. Ningxia Province is pretty close, so the mounted bandits there are a greater threat than Dark Heaven beyond the desert. All the more so for someone like me, who hasn’t learned martial arts.”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, riding alongside us, frowned and cut in.

[3611] Nyang is a traditional unit used to reckon silver currency. Its value varied by period and place.
[3612] Nyang is a traditional unit used to reckon silver currency. Its value varied by period and place.
[3613] Nyang is a traditional unit used to reckon silver currency. Its value varied by period and place.

“Wait. Ningxia was once a lawless land ruled by mounted bandits, but weren’t they put down long ago?”

What was this now?

Everyone turned toward him. The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord cleared his throat and continued.

“To start from the beginning, Ningxia used to be a longstanding headache for us. Hundreds of mounted-bandit groups, large and small, were scattered across the region. Even the government troops couldn’t control them.”

“If even the government troops wouldn’t step in, what happened to the civilians living in Ningxia Province?”

“Would any fish remain in a rotten stream? Most of the civilians either left or joined them.”

“So it was no different from the steppe.”

“You could call it another steppe. Ningxia lies between Gansu and Shaanxi, but it was also the final destination for nomads who’d come down from the north and minority peoples driven out of the Central Plains. And the final touch was…”

“Fugitives. People who’d fled after committing unforgivable crimes.”

Namho cut in, picking up where the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had left off.

“That’s why Ningxia had always been a prize the Murim sects of the Central Plains couldn’t quite bring themselves to claim. The land was small and barren, and the people left there were all sorts of vicious bastards. Even if a sect took losses securing the territory, dealing with it afterward would be another problem. Am I right?”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord smacked his lips softly and nodded.

“I don’t like admitting it, but I can’t deny it. Before the Great Faction War, we could only watch one another. Afterward, we suffered such heavy losses that we had to focus entirely on recovering.”

I was starting to get the picture.

The Nine Sects and One Gang.

The Five Great Families.

They were symbols of the orthodox faction’s honor, but on the other side of the coin, they were a ruling class that had monopolized power and privilege for ages.

Even the Murong Family, which had recently caused a bloodbath, had started harboring other ambitions partly because it had been excluded as a foreign people during the fierce power struggles before the Great Faction War.

Though that’s still nothing but a traitor’s excuse.

I muttered to myself, then asked the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, whose face had reddened as he admitted that shameful truth, the most important question.

"But you said the mounted bandits in Ningxia Province were put down long ago. Which sect led the effort?"

His answer took me by surprise.

"No one stepped forward."

"What?"

"No, they couldn't. Ningxia was already lawless, and not only our sect but every martial faction in the surrounding area had only just recovered from the aftermath of the Great Faction War."

"Then how on earth…"

"I don't know the details, but I've heard Ningxia Province became stable because of one person alone. That was nearly ten years ago."

"…!"

Not a major sect like the Nine Sects and One Gang, but a single individual?

Everyone's eyes widened at the answer they'd never expected.

No wonder. From what we'd heard, Ningxia Province had once been utterly lawless.

It was practically Murim's Wild West. For one person to put down hundreds of mounted-bandit groups…

"A master, then. At least someone who'd reached the Supreme Peak realm."

Jeok Cheongang, who'd been listening in silence, made the brief remark. It matched my own thoughts exactly.

A mysterious Supreme Peak master who swept away countless mounted bandits and pacified Ningxia Province a decade or so ago…

That wasn't the only suspicious thing.

The problem was that Ningxia Province's mounted bandits had started acting strangely after a decade of quiet—long enough for the mountains and rivers to change.

What the hell is going on?

I frowned and rode on in silence until a voice rang out.

"Gansu. It's Gansu!"

Four days had passed since we'd set out from the Jin Family of Taiyuan, driving our horses onward without rest.

Beyond the rugged mountain range that had hidden it from view, a vast plateau spread out before us.

Gansu.

No one could know whether the land before our eyes would become a place of death or a staging ground for another battlefield.

No one.

Chapter 1003

The realization that we'd finally entered Gansu Province brought a strange tension over the group.

It reminded us why we'd come here.

And of the danger lurking somewhere in this land.

How many of us will make it out alive?

I swallowed the thought as soon as it came.

The great battle looming ahead was unavoidable. The only questions were when and where. Countless people would die, and blood would spill across the land.

If not Gansu, then Qinghai. If not Qinghai, then Tibet and Sichuan.

Or it could break out on several fronts at once.

If the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's information was right, Dark Heaven's forces were approaching from beyond the desert. Their numbers rivaled those of the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples—if they didn't surpass them.

An army that size wouldn't have to concentrate on a single target.

As many as the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples, even more dangerous, and they have Moving Formations on top of it all… This isn't going well.

With the Great Nation joining us, our own forces were formidable. But there was no denying that the enemy had more options than we did.

And if even part of my vague suspicion was right, Dark Heaven wasn't just a group held together by dark arts and fanaticism.

It can't be helped. The Murim Alliance leadership knows what Dark Heaven is capable of. I'll have to trust them.

I'd never once held back. I'd survived one brush with death after another, defeated opponents stronger than myself, and fought to prevent even greater disasters.

But I couldn't solve everything alone.

This time was no different.

Just as they'd trusted me, I had to trust them.

One person could light a fuse. Dealing with the aftermath of the explosion took many.

My thoughts came to an end along with the mountain road.

Once we crossed the rugged range between Shaanxi and Gansu, a completely different landscape appeared, as if a layer of camouflage had been pulled away.

High ground, and the cold air that came with it.

Beyond lay a vast, open plain, with ocher-colored city walls rising at its center.

No one could mistake the city that appeared through the blowing sand. This was Tianshui, on the eastern edge of Gansu Province, bordering Shaanxi.

"…Well, that's one hell of an atmosphere."

Hyuk Mujin's uneasy remark probably spoke for all of us.

Bleak. Desolate.

That was my first impression of Gansu, and I suspected most of the others felt the same.

"Ugh, what's with this weather?"

Hyuk Mujin shivered in the chilly, dust-laden wind and pulled his collar shut. Plenty of people were breathing out white clouds.

There were exceptions, of course: those whose Supreme Peak martial arts had brought them to the realm of being Unaffected by Cold and Heat, and Peak masters who could at least use their internal energy to ward off the cold.

Or…

"Taishan likes it! Nice and cool!"

Right. One of them was from here in the first place.

Actually, make that two.

"It's been a while, hasn't it?"

At my question, Sama Pyo stopped looking around and answered.

"Hard to say. It feels strange. I've only been gone a little over a year, but… it feels like ten years."

A little over a year could be short or long, depending on who you asked. I understood how Sama Pyo felt.

From the rebirth of the Murim Alliance to today, we'd faced too many crises together as members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion to fit into so little time.

Yeah. Has it really been that long already…?

Watching Sama Pyo and Taishan return to the place where they'd been born and raised stirred something in me, too.

So much had happened. We could have talked for days without getting through it all.

And at every desperate turn, those two had been beside us.

No. They *were* us.

Comrades bound by the name of the Fire Dragon Pavilion. Men we could trust to watch our backs.

Maybe that was why my gaze lingered on them. Sama Pyo looked back at me, his eyes trembling as though he felt it too.

"Pavilion Master. May I say something?"

"Sure. Anything."

"I have no interest whatsoever in men."

"…What?"

“I trust you don’t either, Pavilion Master, but I thought it best to say so, just in case. I hope there’s no misunderstanding. I’ll be going now.”

“…!”

A moving moment, my ass.

Sama Pyo hurriedly rode ahead. I stared after him, then felt a pointed gaze from beside me and let out a long sigh.

“What? Got something to say?”

The Lower District Sect member who’d been keeping pace with me quickly shook his head.

“No, sir—well, actually, I do, but I’ll say it later.”

“…”

“…”

“Please say it now. Putting it off makes you look even more suspicious.”

“W-Would that be all right?”

“Oh, for the love of—”

He flinched as I scratched the back of my head, then studied my face and spoke.

“The mission I was assigned ends here.”

“Ends here…?”

“I was to evacuate the nearby residents and travelers, then tell Great Hero Jin what’s happened recently. Fortunately, we’ve entered Gansu without incident, so I believe it’s time for me to turn back.”

“Where to?”

“Our sect and the Beggars’ Sect have members watching the western region in case anything happens. I intend to report this to the Branch Leader as quickly as possible.”

The man belonged to the Lower District Sect’s Shaanxi branch, and I knew its Branch Leader well.

Wolhwa, proprietor of Honghwaru in Shanxi Province—and the first martial artist I’d met in this world.

“Give Wolhwa my regards. The Branch Leader, I mean. Tell her I appreciate her looking out for us.”

“The Branch Leader is looking forward to seeing you again, too. She originally planned to come in person while you were passing through Shaanxi, but circumstances…”

He trailed off, reached into his robe, and held something out.

“What’s this?”

“The Branch Leader ordered me to give it directly to you. She told me again and again—make sure, absolutely, don’t you dare forget!”

He offered me a tightly sealed bamboo tube, then gave me a suggestive smile and a thumbs-up.

"Personally, I have a great deal of respect for you."

"…All of a sudden?"

"Doesn't seem all that sudden to me."

I followed his darting eyes and saw Ju Hwaran staring our way. More precisely, she was staring at the bamboo tube he'd extended toward me, her expression subdued.

But only for a moment. As soon as our eyes met, she turned away and began talking to the people beside her as naturally as could be.

It happened so quickly that I wondered if I'd imagined it.

What was that about?

I blinked, then took the tube. With his final task complete, the Lower District Sect member began to slow his horse.

"I'll be going, then. I wish you good fortune in battle."

He clasped his hands in farewell and turned his horse. Just then, something I'd left unresolved flashed through my mind.

"Oh, wait. May I ask one last favor?"

"What would that be?"

"I want to know everything that happens in Qinghai and Gansu. Even the smallest sign. Please get word to us as quickly as you can."

"You needn't worry about that. The Murim Alliance's intelligence network has been operating for some time. Information should already be reaching every nearby sect under emergency orders."

I'd asked out of caution, but I wasn't too worried about it. The Hidden Shadow Pavilion had learned what was happening beyond the desert—a place called the Land of Ruin. That alone showed how broad and thorough our intelligence network was.

There was still one thing on my mind.

"Does that network include Ningxia Province?"

"You're worried about those mounted bandits?"

"From what I've heard, I have reason to be."

Of course I was.

A little over ten years ago, peace had suddenly come to a lawless land that could give the American Wild West a run for its money. At the center of it all was an unidentified Supreme Peak master.

If there was even a chance he was another hidden blade Dark Heaven had planted somewhere in the world, I had to consider turning my horse around right now.

Stopping the enemy coming at us head-on will be hard enough. If we end up fighting on two fronts, it'll be a disaster.

But the Lower District Sect member smiled.

"It seems I didn't explain it well enough. I've worried you for nothing, Great Hero Jin."

"What do you mean?"

"Though it's a frontier region, it's still part of the world. Our sect and several other intelligence groups have been keeping an eye on Ningxia Province for a long time. We watched even more closely after the trouble there ended at the hands of that unidentified master."

"Ah."

I'd overlooked something. Information was money, and that wasn't true only in the modern world. If anything, useful information was even more valuable here.

And despite being spoken of in the same breath as the Beggars' Sect, the Lower District Sect was far less of a martial sect. They were information merchants through and through.

There was no way they'd ignored the major incident in Ningxia Province.

Sure enough, his next words were matter-of-fact enough to make my worries seem misplaced.

"The mounted-bandit gangs in Ningxia Province disbanded long ago. Their most notorious leaders were all killed, and the rest didn't dare resist. We carefully reexamined everything that happened at the time and found nothing particularly suspicious."

"Then what about the mounted bandits said to have appeared nearby?"

"Horse caravans. Or rather, horse caravans made up of people who *used* to be mounted bandits."

Horse caravans.

They roamed the land with their horses and the stars for company. Merchants and guides alike, they were fixtures of the regions they traveled.

"So the disbanded mounted bandits became horse caravans."

He nodded.

"They couldn't remain mounted bandits. Some became horse caravans; others formed merchant companies or Escort Bureaus. They changed with the times."

"Then what about the Supreme Peak master who pacified the mounted bandits?"

"That's the one question we haven't answered. We're told he's remained in Ningxia Province ever since, but no one knows who he is. All we know is that he isn't a fiend. Even our best informants have thrown up their hands."

If he wasn't a fiend, perhaps he was an eccentric recluse from some remote mountain valley.

It wasn’t certain, but his answer eased my mind for now.

The Lower District Sect member set off, and when we reached Tianshui, we came face-to-face with someone we’d never expected to see.

Chapter 1004

Everything in the world has its own atmosphere.

A feeling that belongs not only to a person, but to a place or an object, too.

Ordinary civilians have a hard time reading it clearly. Martial artists are different. Life-or-death battles and grueling training have honed their five senses to their limits.

Jeok Cheongang, for instance, was watching me with a grave, searching gaze.

Why?

Before I could ask, the question vanished.

As we drew closer to the ocher-colored walls rising from the middle of the vast plain, I began to feel it too.

"Hmm."

A low murmur came from nearby.

I turned and met the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's gaze. He had been staring at me.

"You feel it too?"

"Yes."

I nodded, then watched the walls draw closer with every pounding hoofbeat.

"It's quiet. Too quiet."

Anything in excess had poison hidden in it.

That was the feeling coming from the small city, now barely a hundred *jang*[3614] away.

The Great Nation's flag flew above the walls, as it did everywhere, and below it stood a firmly shut iron gate.

But even setting aside the unusual desolation, something essential was missing.

People.

Civilians didn't spend their whole lives inside city walls. Some worked the fields outside; others traveled the roads.

Yet the sun hadn't set, and there were few signs of anyone.

No—not a single person was in sight.

No people meant no noise, making the place feel all the more eerie.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had noticed it too. His voice grew heavier.

"Do you think it could be a trap?"

I fell silent for a moment.

According to the Lower District Sect member Wolhwa had sent, the Murim Alliance already had a tight surveillance network throughout the western region.

[3614] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Could an entire city—not some small village—have been occupied without them knowing?

Besides…

It's eerie, but that's all.

I could see no signs of battle, and the wind carried not a trace of blood.

How much flesh and bone had I cut through by now? I knew the thick, cloying stench of blood wouldn't vanish in a day or two. Not when taking a city would have spilled so much of it.

It's not a trap.

Just as I reached that conclusion, Sama Pyo urged his horse up beside us. One calm remark turned my guess into certainty.

"There's no harm in continuing on as we are. Nothing's going to happen anyway."

His voice was steady, his gaze just as calm.

A thought struck me.

"Could it be?"

"That's right. It looks like they've prepared quite an extravagant welcome."

At that moment—

Rumble.

Several dozen *jang*[3615] ahead, the firmly shut iron gate began to slowly open.

As the enormous mass of iron, weighing over a thousand *geun*[3616], parted, a cold-faced middle-aged man appeared in the gap.

He was slender but powerfully built. Though he was entering old age, his neatly combed, jet-black hair held not a single gray strand.

He reminded me of a black panther, and an epithet and name I'd only heard spoken flashed through my mind.

The Black Night King, Sima Gong.

Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, which stood alongside the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance as a great power of the unorthodox faction. Together with the Kongtong Sect, it divided Gansu Province between them.

But as I recognized the father, I noticed something else.

For some reason, the closer he came, the more his son's eyes darkened.

"This junior martial artist, Sima Gong, pays his respects to you, Senior."

[3615] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3616] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand *geun* is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

Sima Gong's greeting to Jeok Cheongang was more than polite. It was almost excessive, especially given his standing in Murim and his own considerable age.

Jeok Cheongang, of course, didn't care in the slightest.

"Spare me the 'junior martial artist' nonsense."

He snorted so hard I worried a booger might fly out, then looked at Sima Gong.

"Are you that desperate to pretend you're young, or do you wish you were young again?"

Sima Gong lowered his clasped hands and straightened.

"That wasn't my intention, but embarrassing as it is to admit, I suppose both."

"Your silver tongue hasn't changed."

"Nor have you, Senior. Though your appearance has changed quite a bit."

"The shell may change, but what's inside stays the same. Speaking of shells, yours has grown rather grand."

Jeok Cheongang paused to survey the area.

The streets were empty of civilians—not even a rat was in sight—and around a thousand armed men filled the space by the city gate.

Their black martial uniforms left no doubt that they belonged to the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

"You brought plenty with you. Swarming around like a pack of dogs. Quite a sight."

Displeasure filled Jeok Cheongang's eyes and voice.

For the three hundred years since its founding, the Fire Gate Clan had walked the line between the orthodox and unorthodox factions. If pressed, though, it leaned a little closer to the orthodox side.

The Black Night King Sima Gong and the Black Dragon Demon Gate he led, on the other hand, were heirs to the tradition of demonic, heterodox arts.

And judging from the things I'd heard about Sima Gong in the time we'd spent together, Jeok Cheongang's opinion of him had been poor ever since the Great Faction War.

"Things have been looking rather strange lately, so it came to this."

"So you emptied your sect and came pouring over here because things are unsettled? Stirring up innocent civilians while you're at it."

"You seem to have misunderstood. Even with this many troops away, our sect's defenses remain secure. The civilians left of their own accord. If they were frightened because of us, then there's nothing we can do about that… but it isn't necessarily a bad thing, is it?"

"What?"

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes. Sima Gong smiled gently, an expression at odds with his cold face.

"I have no intention of being disrespectful to you, Senior. I only meant that, amid these signs, the civilians would sense a greater danger. That, too, could be a way to save their lives."

"…!"

I had to admit one thing.

This guy can talk.

He could dress up word games and sophistry to sound convincing, then soothe the person listening with just the right manner and smile.

On top of that, he had martial arts that could rival the two Alliance Leaders of the Yangtze and the Green Forest. That was probably the biggest reason the Black Dragon Demon Gate was what it was today.

Like father, like son? They're definitely alike in that respect. Sama Pyo was just like that when I first met him.

That was then, though.

At our first meeting, Sama Pyo had spoken and acted like a slippery eel. The longer we spent together, the more I realized he wasn't actually much of a talker.

Was "keep your outside and inside different" something his father taught him?

I glanced between father and son—and met Sima Gong's eyes.

"Oh, so that's the young man. The rare genius you took in as a Disciple, Senior."

He was speaking to Jeok Cheongang, but the interest gleaming in his eyes was directed at me.

It was already too late to pretend I hadn't noticed his gaze and look away. I glanced at Jeok Cheongang, who was still frowning at Sima Gong. He nodded.

"I'm Jin Taekyung, of the Jin Family of Taiyuan."

"I know. How could I not? There's hardly anyone in Gansu who hasn't heard of your fame."

It was the same tired pleasantry people exchanged whenever they met in Murim. But he'd said it with a smile, so I had to answer in kind.

After all, the man before me was an ally—and Sama Pyo's father.

"You're too kind. I've heard a great deal about you too, Great Hero Sima."

I clasped my hands politely. Sima Gong smiled and turned to Jeok Cheongang.

"Well, this is unexpected. I thought you'd never had a very good opinion of me, Senior."

"Never had a good opinion of you? Me?"

"Was I mistaken?"

"Of course you were."

Well, even Jeok Cheongang couldn't spit in the face of a smiling man.

I gave Sima Gong a warm smile, as if to say, *See?*

Then Jeok Cheongang went on.

“It’s not that I have a poor opinion of you. I just don’t like you.”

“…”

“So I’ve talked behind your back a little.”

“…”

“Jin Taekyung there is lying through his teeth. ‘Heard a great deal about you,‘ my ass. What kind of bullshit is—”

Whoosh. Thwack!

“Gyaaaah!”

The faint sound of something cutting through the air was followed by a sudden scream that swallowed Jeok Cheongang’s voice.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

At the same time, dazzling flashes of swordlight sprang up in every direction, and shouts rang out.

“Prepare for battle!”

“The Black Dragon Demon Gate, prepare for an enemy attack!”

“By order of the Sect Leader! Zhongnan Disciples, form the Moon-Shattering Sword Formation at once! …What are you doing?”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had been ordering his Disciples to form a sword formation, but his voice trailed off in bafflement. Only then did everyone realize something was strange. Following the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord’s gaze, they all looked toward one person.

A homely-looking guy who’d fallen from his saddle with a thunderous scream.

No, Hyuk Mujin.

“Ugh, what the hell was that all of a—”

He groaned and staggered to his feet, then froze like a statue.

Countless eyes were fixed on him like spotlights. He blinked silently until he finally spotted me. The corners of his eyes twitched.

“Captain. That was you, wasn’t it?”

Everyone’s gaze shifted to me.

Sima Gong’s eyes in particular were fixed on me. I did my best to keep my expression calm as I opened my mouth.

“Don’t misunderstand. I don’t really know him.”

Sima Gong turned to Hyuk Mujin.

“Who are you? You don’t seem to be a Zhongnan Sect Disciple.”

“I’m Hyuk Mujin, of the Jin Family of Taiyuan,” he answered indignantly.

“So he says,” Sima Gong said.

Of all the times to be oblivious, you idiot.

I should’ve knocked him out in one shot. Since when did he get so sturdy?

Cursing myself for failing to land the Finger Qi properly, I said, “We’ve met a few times. I didn’t say I’d never met him.”

“So you do know him.”

“Hmm. I suppose I do.”

“Then what do you think caused that young man to suddenly scream and fall over?”

In the suffocating silence, I considered my options and gave the best answer I could.

“He’s always been a bit sick. He has a condition.”

Hyuk Mujin’s mouth fell open. Perhaps the pain had stimulated his salivary glands, because a translucent string of drool ran down his chin.

“See? He comes and goes a few times a day. This sort of thing happens as regularly as his three meals—”

“Wow, you’re really going to do this? You’re seriously going to do this? You want to take it all the way?”

At that critical moment, I sent a discreet Sound Transmission over Hyuk Mujin’s shoulder.

More precisely, to the quick-witted Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent behind him, whose eyes were darting in alarm.

Now!

Fortunately, Namho was nothing like Hyuk Mujin.

With speed and agility that belied his age, he stealthily dropped the strip of jerky in his hand onto the top of Hyuk Mujin’s head.

That tempting piece of jerky was enough to rouse the appetite of someone who’d gone a whole *shichen*[3617] without food.

“Nooo! Jerky!”

Whack!

A palm as big as a pot lid slammed down on Hyuk Mujin’s head. He collapsed, and a deathly silence followed.

It lasted until I, having barely dealt with the emergency, spoke up.

“Now, don’t mind him. Let’s all go inside.”

“…”

“…”

Why are they all looking at me like I’m a madman?

[3617] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Chapter 1005

Four days.

You couldn't exactly call that a long time.

But if you'd spent all four days riding hard, barely stopping to rest and catching snatches of sleep in the saddle, that was another matter.

Rest while you can. Who knows when we'll have another chance?

Jin Taekyung had left them with those words, then gone off to a meeting with the leadership. The Fire Dragon Pavilion members he'd left behind had followed their Pavilion Master's orders to the letter.

Now they'd unpacked their few belongings, bathed in warm water, and settled before a sumptuous feast that had somehow already been laid out.

Naturally, Jeok Cheongang and Sama Pyo were the exceptions.

Jeok Cheongang was the Fire King, a giant of his generation. His place at the meeting needed no explanation. And as Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, Sama Pyo belonged among the leadership too.

"Whew. I finally feel alive again."

Ju Hwaran spoke for every member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Physical exhaustion was bad enough, but mental fatigue weighed on both body and mind far more heavily.

What could they do?

For a martial artist, crossing the line between life and death was a lifelong fate. The grief and pain brought on by war were the lot of those living through troubled times.

It had always been that way, and it would stay that way.

At least everyone in the Fire Dragon Pavilion understood their circumstances—and had accepted them.

"Our Pavilion Master was right. We have to rest as much as we can while there's time, so we're ready for what comes next. With that in mind, let's eat."

At Song Ilseom's invitation, Hyuk Mujin looked up, his cheeks already bulging with food.

"Wha'?"

"…"

"Wha' did you jus' say?"

"…"

"Sounded like you said somethin'."

Song Ilseom stared at him in silence, then answered.

"Nothing. Don't worry about it. Go ahead and eat. The more pain you're in, the hungrier you get."

“Ah, okay.”

Perhaps the bump on the crown of his head was bothering him. Now that he’d paused, Hyuk Mujin took the opportunity to rub it, then buried his face in his plate again.

A moment later, he looked up and stared at Song Ilseom.

“Wait. Why’re you talkin’ down to me? I don’t like that.”

“I’ve been doing it this whole time.”

“That’s why I don’t like it. I’ve told you a bunch of times not to.”

“It’s simple. I’m older than you.”

Gulp.

Hyuk Mujin swallowed what was in his mouth and frowned.

“What a ridiculous guy. You’re only a year or two older than me.”

“Does a year or two not count as an age difference?”

“Well… I guess it does.”

“And you know perfectly well that I have more experience as a martial artist.”

“That too… I guess.”

“I’m your senior, and I’m older. So what’s the problem?”

The longer the conversation went on, the worse things got for Hyuk Mujin.

His eyes darted about as he searched for a counterargument. Then an idea came to him.

“You know how old our Captain is, right?”

“More or less.”

“He’s way younger than me.”

“So?”

“Hey, what do you mean, ‘So?‘ You speak at least somewhat politely to the Captain. Why do you get to talk down to me—”

“So?”

“…Huh?”

“So. What are you going to do about it?”

“…”

There was nothing he could say to that.

As Hyuk Mujin blinked at Song Ilseom’s absurdly confident expression, anger rose from deep in his chest.

Now that he thought about it, how unfair was this?

He could put up with Jin Taekyung giving him a hard time whenever he got the chance. That much he could gladly accept as his Captain’s loyal right hand and self-proclaimed heart.

But now he was getting the same treatment from Song Ilseom—a mere wandering martial artist who'd joined them along the way. Sure, Song Ilseom was famous as hell among wanderers, and, as it turned out, he came from an impressive martial family. But still!

I mean, come on! By rank, I'm the Vice Pavilion Master of the Fire Dragon Pavilion! And the Jin Family of Taiyuan is one of the Five Great Families now!

Fire lit in Hyuk Mujin's eyes as he glared at Song Ilseom. The roasted chicken leg he'd been holding trembled like a sword resonating with its wielder.

"Planning to throw that thing you're holding?"

"Why? Think I can't?"

At Hyuk Mujin's chilly reply, Song Ilseom nodded without hesitation.

"Of course you can't."

"That's right. You know me well."

"But you'll have to deal with what happens afterward… Wait, what did you say?"

"If you throw away food, heaven will punish you. Besides, my parents always told me to get along with the people around me."

"…"

"What? Got something to say? Then say it quickly. I'm hungry, and I don't want this precious food to get cold."

Was that confidence? Cowardice?

Or both?

What is with this guy?

How could anyone be so brazen about being a coward?

Song Ilseom watched Hyuk Mujin with a thoroughly unimpressed look, then spoke.

"…Never mind. You had good parents."

"They're simple, good-hearted people. Thanks for the compliment."

Hyuk Mujin replied as if he'd been waiting for those words, then set to work sweeping the food in front of him into his mouth with renewed vigor. Song Ilseom sighed inwardly.

Every last one of them is out of their minds.

They'd been told to rest and take it easy, but who would look at them and think they were about to go into battle?

A pack of beggars come to bankrupt an inn, maybe.

Or do they not feel fear at all?

Song Ilseom had spent years among wandering martial artists, where crazies were everywhere. But the people he'd been with for the past year or so were strange from top to bottom.

For example…

True madness.

They were on another level from any madman he'd met before.

And Hyuk Mujin, who was already plenty crazy himself, was merely average by Fire Dragon Pavilion standards.

First, there was Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King.

"…"

No words were needed. Just thinking about him made Song Ilseom's breath catch.

Watching Jeok Cheongang up close had driven one point home once again: the law of the strong devouring the weak still ruled this world.

Otherwise, he'd have been dead several times over by now.

Why did Song Ilseom think that?

Simple.

Jeok Cheongang beat the living daylights out of anyone he didn't like. Anyone at all. He was fair about it, at least.

Their sect, their principles, their age, their sex—it made no difference.

If they belonged to the orthodox faction, he'd cut them to the heart with a tongue sharper than a famous sword. If they were from the unorthodox faction or were dark-path figures, he'd look for an opening to throw a punch. As for fiends, he'd once said:

> "I may as well tell you now: for many years, this old man's wish has been to reform every fiend beneath heaven and make them good."

Jin Taekyung had asked on everyone's behalf if he'd gone senile. Jeok Cheongang had beaten his own Disciple senseless, then added, as brazen as ever:

> "Of course, the only good fiend is a dead fiend."

That was the kind of person Jeok Cheongang was.

Why else would his one and only Disciple say this about his own Master?

> "I thought about it seriously, and helping the orthodox faction during the Great Faction War was the best move that old man ever made. Now he gets to be called a king and wreak havoc wherever he wants, all perfectly legally. Am I right, everyone?"

Jin Taekyung probably didn't know.

Everyone had agreed with him, but the moment he turned away, they'd exchanged looks that all meant roughly the same thing.

> *Look who's talking.*
> *How does he have the nerve to say that?*
> *Does our Captain even know what the word "conscience" means?*
> *Sorry, Young Master Jin. This is a bit much, even for you…*
> *Taishan hungry.*

No one dared say it outright, but everyone knew the only person crazier than Jeok Cheongang was Jin Taekyung.

That guy's the real lunatic, in more ways than one.

His martial arts were insane, and so was his temper.

Sometimes, for reasons known only to him, he'd act like a perfectly normal person. But when something rubbed him the wrong way, he could outdo even his Master, Jeok Cheongang.

In that sense, he's even worse.

If Song Ilseom had to fight either Jeok Cheongang or Jin Taekyung, he'd choose the former without hesitation.

Because he thought Jeok Cheongang's martial arts were no match for his Disciple's anymore?

Wrong.

Even if Jeok Cheongang cursed him with every filthy word he knew until Song Ilseom feared qi deviation, even if his Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist crushed Song Ilseom's Eight Extraordinary Meridians[3618], Jeok Cheongang would still be preferable.

Because he was the Fire King.

A giant known throughout the world, an old monster who had lived through ages beyond counting.

But Jin Taekyung?

…I don't even want to think about it.

Just thinking about him made Song Ilseom's stomach churn.

His martial prowess, now so far beyond Song Ilseom's reach, was one thing. But his tongue, widely held to have surpassed even his Master's, was the stuff of nightmares.

The one small comfort was that his terrifying tongue only ever seemed to show its full power against enemies.

Even aside from that, Song Ilseom was among those who got the least grief from Jin Taekyung, along with Sama Pyo and Ju Hwaran.

[3618] In traditional Chinese medicine, the Eight Extraordinary Meridians are channels distinct from the twelve principal meridians.

Even when he did something worth getting chewed out for, Jin Taekyung would just toss out a short line and turn away.

> “So boring.”

Song Ilseom didn’t know exactly what the expression meant, but he could guess it wasn’t a compliment.

He said I was “so boring.” He called Sama Pyo “ten times more boring.” But he didn’t say anything to Young Lady Ju.

What else could that mean? It was obvious.

Song Ilseom had once spent a long time seriously puzzling over the exact meaning of the expression, but at some point he’d stopped caring.

Had he gotten used to it?

Maybe. Or maybe…

“Hmm.”

With that unconscious murmur, Song Ilseom surfaced from his thoughts.

Only then did he notice what was happening around him—and realize that something was terribly wrong.

“What on earth… is going on?”

It wasn’t a question directed at anyone in particular. It was closer to an exclamation of shock.

Song Ilseom froze, eyes wide. Ju Hwaran and Hyuk Mujin, both wearing serious expressions, answered in turn.

“We don’t know either. How did this happen?”

“Incredibuh! Makes no shensh!”

Ju Hwaran’s answer was full of worry. Hyuk Mujin’s was full of food.

Pth, pth!

Ordinarily, Song Ilseom would have dodged the spray of food with a quick movement. This time, he couldn’t.

Splut!

Something unpleasant touched his skin.

Hyuk Mujin froze, worried about what he’d done. But despite his fears, Song Ilseom didn’t move.

He could only stare at one person, as stunned as if he’d come face-to-face with a living dragon.

Taishan sat before a mouthwatering feast, his shoulders drooping, without moving a muscle.

“Am I seeing things?”

The disbelieving words had barely left someone’s lips when another voice answered.

“You’re seeing it right. But I’d like you to keep it down for now.”

The voice was low and subdued.

Namho, who’d sat motionless and lost in thought all this time, twitched his nose.

As if trying to catch a scent he remembered from a day not so long ago.

Chapter 1006

Rustle.

A thick animal hide unfurled across the large table. Its surface, tanned by human hands, was covered edge to edge with drawings and writing that detailed the terrain.

“As you can see, this map was made by our sect. We’ve spent many years documenting every feature of Gansu in detail, revising each change as it occurred, until it was complete.”

Sima Gong’s voice was calm, but every leader gathered around the table understood what the map meant.

A province might sound like a mere piece of the world, but even the smallest was comparable in size to a country. And it wasn’t as if they had drones or satellites. Making a map like this took enormous wealth and manpower.

The Black Dragon Demon Gate’s ability to produce one so vast and detailed showed how much control it held across Gansu. It also showed the reach of Sima Gong’s intelligence network.

“You must’ve put a lot of work into this. So what, are you trying to brag that you’ve got this whole area locked down?”

Jeok Cheongang had no use for subtlety. A faint smile appeared on Sima Gong’s lips.

“Of course not. The Kongtong Sect is one of the pillars of the Central Plains. How could we presume to claim Gansu for ourselves?”

His words were humble, but everyone knew where Sima Gong and the Black Dragon Demon Gate stood in Gansu Province.

And besides…

“This is an important meeting, but that very pillar is missing.”

It was true. The Kongtong Sect wasn’t here.

Even after I’d pointed that out, Sima Gong’s smile didn’t waver.

“No need to worry. The pillar is elsewhere, preparing to hold back the downpour that’s about to come.”

“So the Kongtong Sect has already been sent to the front lines.”

Sima Gong nodded at the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, who’d cut in.

“Just as the Sect Leader guessed. We’ve established three lines of defense stretching across Dunhuang, the Great Snow Mountain, and the Qilian Mountains in Gansu Province.”

“Three lines? Aren’t your forces spread too thin?”

The others in the room nodded at the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord’s concern.

If Dark Heaven's vast army marched into Gansu, a single great battle could decide everything. But Sima Gong's expression remained unchanged.

"They may not rival Kunlun, but the Great Snow Mountain and the Qilian Mountains are both among the ten most treacherous mountain ranges under heaven. And our enemies have that bizarre dark art they call the Moving Formation. We judged it too dangerous to concentrate all our forces in Dunhuang."

"I agree with you, Sect Leader Sima. The question is whether you have enough forces to hold three fronts."

Being outnumbered was our greatest obstacle.

The enemy had an army of a hundred thousand. Even if they split their forces to attack three provinces at once, that still left more than thirty thousand pouring into each one like a pack of dogs.

To face that many, we need to gather in one place. And we'll only stand a chance if we make the most of the terrain.

That was how we'd fought in Shanxi Province not long ago. Luck and determination together had won us the day.

Anyone could see the problem, whether they knew military strategy or not. And Sima Gong was no village bumpkin. He was the Black Night King, the man who'd built the Black Dragon Demon Gate into a major power. Could he really have missed something so obvious?

No way.

He met everyone's gaze without a trace of unease. I could sense the confidence behind his calm.

"You already have enough forces in Gansu."

Sima Gong's smile deepened.

"About a month ago, I put all of Gansu Murim on alert. Our sect, the Kongtong Sect, and every other martial faction in the area had already been keeping watch for some time, so we were able to gather our forces quickly."

Which means…

"Thirty thousand. That's how many we've assembled so far. We've mobilized everything Gansu Murim has."

"…!"

"…!"

The leaders' eyes widened. Mine did too.

Thirty thousand?

It was an enormous force. Shanxi Province had fielded only fifteen thousand to hold Eight Spring Gorge against the forces of the Great Steppe.

And Sima Gong had specified *Gansu Murim*. All thirty thousand were martial artists. There was no comparing that to Shanxi's army, more than half of which had been government soldiers.

Granted, Shanxi Murim had already suffered grievous losses in the conflict with the Mount Heng Sword Sect and the Head Elder's betrayal. Even taking that into account, thirty thousand was almost beyond imagining.

"W-where did you find that many people?"

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had voiced what everyone must have been wondering. Jeok Cheongang, who'd been watching with a frown, spoke before Sima Gong could answer.

"Unorthodox factions have always had numbers, if nothing else. Isn't that right?"

Sima Gong smiled and nodded.

"I won't deny it."

"Even so, thirty thousand would be nearly impossible for the Nine Sects and One Gang of the Central Plains."

"That's also true. Would the Great Nation have stood idly by if this many ruffians, liable to turn the swords at their waists against the state at any moment, had gathered?"

The phrase *the government and Murim shall not interfere in one another's affairs* had been rendered nearly meaningless since the Son of Heaven declared Dark Heaven traitors. But the principle had arisen for a reason.

It was an unspoken rule that had arisen naturally alongside Murim itself.

A stone that stuck out was bound to get hammered down. The countless martial factions scattered across the land had long checked one another and made agreements to avoid conflict. In turn, the Great Nation tolerated them so long as they posed no threat to its foundations.

People even said that dynasties changed, but Murim remained.

Now Gansu Murim had crossed that unspoken line. They'd gathered thirty thousand martial artists in the frontier, not even the Central Plains. That was an army they couldn't have raised even if they'd turned every martial faction in Gansu Province upside down and shaken them out.

Which means…

Only one possibility remained. The majority had no affiliation with any particular sect. They were the sort of people who followed only their own needs and interests.

"You even scraped together the dark-path figures. You must've been desperate."

The dark path.

Those people had coexisted uneasily with Murim for ages. Several faces darkened at the mention of them, and the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's eyes grew especially grave.

“Sect Leader Sima. Is what Great Hero Jeok said true?”

Sima Gong answered calmly.

“Some of them are dark-path figures. Is that a problem?”

“Well…”

“I won’t pretend otherwise. I’m an unorthodox martial artist. The Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance have their roots in the dark path. Ah, and so does that son of mine over there.”

Sama Pyo, silent until now, looked shaken at being singled out by his father. But Sima Gong spoke again, drawing everyone’s attention back.

“And all the people I just mentioned have one thing in common. Do you know what it is?”

They did. Everyone in the room knew.

Yet they remained silent, their expressions heavy.

All but one.

“They fought for the Murim Alliance, and they’re fighting for it now.”

Jeok Cheongang.

Sima Gong’s reflection appeared in his reddish, fever-bright eyes, befitting the title of Fire King.

“Unorthodox, dark-path figures, or nobodies who crawled in from God knows where—I don’t give a damn. If the weapons in their hands are pointed at Dark Heaven, that’s all that matters.”

Sima Gong nodded, his face set.

“As it was in the past, so it will be this time.”

“I’m not doubting you. But dark-path figures who’ve drifted all the way out to this frontier must be a rotten lot. If something goes wrong…”

“I’ll stake my head on it.”

Jeok Cheongang stared at him in silence. Then he turned and swept his gaze around the room.

“What do you all think?”

Respected elders of Gansu Murim had come to greet us alongside Sima Gong, but Jeok Cheongang wasn’t asking them. His question was for the senior members of the Zhongnan Sect who’d traveled with us.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord stood at their center, hesitating. His Senior Brothers, the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword, answered one after the other.

“Someone once said it doesn’t matter whether a cat is white or black, so long as it catches mice.”

“The Sima Gong I know is a comrade-in-arms and a hero, someone who weathered the war alongside us, before he is an unorthodox martial artist. That a man like him should have to stake his life on this—isn’t that a crying shame?”

I watched the two old Daoists pour out their answers as smoothly as if they’d been waiting for their turn. Then Jeok Cheongang looked my way.

“So, are you done stuffing your face with honey?”

He meant I’d been sitting there with my mouth full, acting like I couldn’t speak. I smacked my lips and answered.

“Yeah. It was sweet.”

“You’ve held that precious honey in your mouth long enough. You must have something to say by now.”

“Is this something I get to decide?”

“Not a chance. Who do you think you are?”

I gave a short laugh and looked around.

Most of the faces were unfamiliar; I knew neither their names nor their titles. There were senior members of the Black Dragon Demon Gate and leaders of Gansu Murim, each of them heading a martial faction large or small.

Sima Gong was at their center.

“Can I ask a few questions?”

“Anything.”

“I doubt you made all these decisions alone. Am I right?”

“Of course. The Sect Leaders here agreed, as did the Kongtong Sect.”

“Then if Dark Heaven isn’t targeting Gansu…”

“We’ll leave some forces behind and head straight for Qinghai. But that won’t happen.”

“Why not?”

“The signs are troubling. The enemy beyond the desert used to be the Demonic Cult; now it’s Dark Heaven. Either way, they’ve always been our greatest concern, even after the Great Faction War.”

“What signs?”

“It’s too early to say. I’ve already selected people I can trust and sent them to scout beyond the desert. We’ll know for certain when they return. So…”

Sima Gong’s gaze moved from me to Jeok Cheongang.

“Please leave Gansu’s defenses to us and go to Qinghai, Senior. Even with reinforcements from Huashan and the others, Qinghai is the place where every moment counts.”

“Qinghai… Qinghai.”

Jeok Cheongang murmured the name, almost groaning.

That was when a frantic voice rang out through the gap between the tightly shut doors.

“S-Sect Leader!”

Chapter 1007

For anyone born and raised in Gansu Province, the pale sandstorms that swept through year-round were nothing unusual.

Their ancestors had recorded the loess-colored plateau's existence as far back as the days when the river flowing through the region came to be called the Yellow River.

No one knew exactly when the plateau had formed or why, but it was still there. Whenever a strong wind blew in, a cloud would rise like a waterspout and sweep across the area before vanishing, scattering fine loess like stars.

That was probably why the Black Dragon Demon Gate martial artists standing watch atop the city wall felt nothing in particular as they watched a cloud of dust approach from the far north.

"Damn it. Here we go again."

One of the martial artists frowned. The middle-aged squad leader pulled a scrap of cloth from inside his clothes with a practiced motion.

"Shut your mouth and put on your mask. Don't stand there trying to tough it out like last time, then complain for days afterward."

"I really couldn't help it that time. How are you supposed to dodge it when it hits all at once? You can't even breathe."

"Suit yourself. If you'd rather eat a handful of sand than your next meal."

The others were chuckling when someone watching the cloud of dust spoke up.

"Still, this one's little. Almost cute. Looks like it'll die down before it reaches us. The scouts way out front are going to get covered in it, though."

"Oh, you're right. Captain, why'd you put on your mask?"

They'd been through this often enough to know what they were looking at. This wasn't a sandstorm towering more than ten jang[3619] high. There was no need to make a fuss over a little cloud of dust.

Without bothering to take another look, the martial artists teased the Captain for putting on his mask so early.

"Look at you, Captain. You've lost your touch."

"The Blood-Death Sword will be weeping. Heh."

"Come on, you can tell how big it is at a glance. Why the rush? I used to be a mounted bandit, and I know thirty riders galloping side by side kick up a cloud about that size. It's nothing."

The Captain's already fearsome face twisted into something monstrous.

"What?"

[3619] A jang is a traditional unit of length equal to ten cheok, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

The laughter slowly died. His subordinates remembered how notorious the Captain had once been in the area and swallowed hard.

"W-we didn't mean it like that, Captain…"

But his next words left them staring at him in confusion.

"No, not that."

"Pardon?"

"The last thing he said. What was it?"

Everyone turned toward the former mounted bandit. He blinked.

"Me?"

"Yes. Say that again."

"Uh, you can tell how big it is at a glance, so why the rush—"

"Not that, you bastard! The part after it!"

"Th-that a cloud of dust that size means about thirty riders…"

"And how many scouts left half a shichen[3620] ago?"

"Exactly thirty. Was that when they got their horses earlier? I remember because they made a huge fuss, demanding better mounts since they had to patrol until sunset…"

His voice cut off.

Only then did the martial artists realize something was wrong. Their eyes darted between one another as they carried on a silent conversation.

Wait. What's going on?

An unusually small cloud of dust. Thirty riders. And thirty scouts.

Something feels off.

Why are they back already if they're not due until after sunset?

That feels even more off.

Maybe someone had to take a dump?

You can shit anywhere, cover it up, and call it a latrine. What kind of lunatic would abandon a mission just to come back and relieve himself?

Doesn't everyone? I do.

You're a real lunatic.

This feels seriously wrong.

No matter how they put their heads together, no matter what explanation they came up with, something was clearly amiss.

Gulp.

In the strange tension, just as someone swallowed dryly—

Fwoooosh! Boom!

[3620] A shichen is a traditional time period of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Hundreds of jang away, red smoke shot up from the pale cloud of dust. The Captain recognized what the signal flare assigned to the scouts meant and forced his voice out.

“Suspicious person spotted…!”

That was the signal for someone acting strangely—an unfamiliar intruder.

At last realizing what was happening, the martial artists atop the wall shouted as if coughing up blood.

“This is real! It’s really happening!”

“What are you waiting for, you bastards? Move your asses!”

“L-let the Sect Leader know! Hurry!”

The wall erupted into chaos as if a powder magazine had exploded. Meanwhile, the flare that had burst brilliantly in the sky slowly drifted down over the thirty scouts racing toward them with all their might, raising a cloud of dust.

On one of the dozens of winding hills, a group stood watching with the shadows at their backs.

“Well… this is a hell of a mess.”

There were about fifty unidentified riders. At their head, a giant of a man let out a low groan. Another man beside him scratched vigorously at his shaggy hair.

“Ah, damn it. This is driving me crazy. Didn’t your little brother tell you we should approach slowly and gently?”

The giant frowned.

“I didn’t think they’d panic and run. We even brought a white flag just in case. Why are those bastards so scared?”

“Do you really need to ask? Look at your face, Big Brother. Who’s going to take a white flag as a friendly gesture from someone who looks like you?”

Agreement erupted from all around them.

“He’s right. Your face is downright terrifying. What good’s a white flag going to do?”

“They probably thought you were offering your condolences in advance to the poor bastards about to die.”

“It wouldn’t have helped if you’d gone over dressed in white instead.”

“Then they’d think you’d put on mourning clothes in advance to offer your condolences to the poor bastards about to die.”

“No need to say another word. Not even the Heavenly Demon’s granddaddy could beat Big Brother at looking vicious.”

“Damn it. This whole thing’s going to shit, and now I’m getting nervous. What if we ride over there and they shower us with arrows?”

“Can’t be helped. Big Brother, since it’s come to this, let’s just turn around and go back.”

“Second Brother, are you scared?”

“Bah! Who’s scared? I just remembered I left something important behind!”

“Looks like you brought your shriveled-up guts along… Ah, you left your balls behind.”

“Bah! Third Brother, how dare you!”

“There you go again with the *bah, bah*. That only sounds impressive when a Supreme Peak master says it. You can’t pull it off, Second Brother.”

“Bah! Must you see your own coffin before you learn your lesson?”

“I’m going to lose my mind if I have to keep listening to that. You’ve picked up a weird habit. So, Big Brother, what are you going to do?”

At the question from the man called Third Brother, the giant, who’d stayed silent through the rapid-fire exchange, finally spoke.

“We’re not turning back.”

His voice was as heavy as his build. He fixed his gaze on the loess-colored wall rising beyond the heat haze.

“I know what you’re all worried about… But Great Sir asked this of us himself. If you’re men who understand loyalty, follow my lead.”

“…!”

“…!”

The six men who called him Big Brother stared at him, their eyes trembling at his stern words.

The mutters that followed, however, weren’t the reaction he’d hoped for.

“There he goes, putting on a show again.”

“Now we’re the bad guys.”

“He’s a bear until it suits him to be a fox. Am I right, brothers?”

“Still, we should do as Big Brother says. Besides, Great Sir himself asked us. What choice do we have?”

“Bah…!”

“Please, someone gag Second Brother. Listening to him is going to give me qi deviation.”

Most of them grumbled like children whose sweets had been taken away. But they knew, as did the giant and the dozens of riders watching from behind them, that their purpose hadn’t changed just because things had turned out this way.

The strongest reason for that certainty was the person who had sent them here.

“Let’s go. The sun’ll set at this rate.”

With the late sunset beginning to spread from the west, the giant led the fifty or so riders over the hill.

Before long, they reached the wall. Hundreds of arrowheads were trained on them, with unfamiliar faces visible between them.

“Stop! Stop! Stop! Hands up! Move and we’ll shoot!”

At the shout from some young pretty boy, the giant calmly reached inside his clothes for the white flag he’d prepared.

Or rather, he tried to.

Before he could pull it out, the young man gave an order he hadn’t expected.

“Fire!”

“…Huh?”

Fwoosh, fwoosh, fwoosh, fwoosh!

Hundreds of arrows tore through the air.

Some carried more force than others, but every arrow, large or small, had been imbued with internal energy. Instead of arcing, they plunged straight down at the unexpected visitors.

Clang-clang-clang-clang!

Sparks flew in every direction.

The giant had ridden ahead alone, leaving his dozens of subordinates behind. He survived the net of arrows that covered a thirty-jang radius and bellowed.

“Are you out of your damn mind? Who starts shooting arrows without warning?”

Jeok Cheongang, standing beside me, nodded.

“He looks vicious as hell, but this old man has to agree with him. Has some inner demon taken hold of you?”

“No, I’m fine.”

“Then why?”

“I told him to put his hands up, and he didn’t listen. That bastard tried to pull a fast one.”

“You’re insane.”

“Honestly, I didn’t think they’d actually shoot. I thought they’d ignore my order. Judging by his level, though, I figured he’d survive a volley like that, so it was a warning too. Anyway, no harm done, right?”

“Infinite Life Buddha…”[3621]

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord looked appalled by my clear-cut conclusion. The Black Night King, Sima Gong, burst into hearty laughter instead.

“Haha! Straight to the point. We could’ve used someone like you on our side.”

“…”

Was that a compliment or an insult?

[3621] “Infinite Life Buddha” is an invocation of Amitabha Buddha, whose name refers to infinite life.

While I considered how to respond, the giant—whose face was so vicious I could hardly believe anyone could look like that—shouted again.

“Don’t shoot! I said don’t shoot! Can’t you see what I’m holding?”

Flap.

So that was why he’d reached inside his clothes. He was waving a large piece of cloth.

It was covered in sand and loess, leaving it a thoroughly ambiguous yellowish color.

“What on earth is that supposed to mean? What does he want us to see on that dingy yellow thing?”

“Yellow cloth… Wait, could he be a Yellow Turban?”[3622]

“That’s ridiculous. What era do you think this is? How could the Yellow Turbans still be around?”

Watching everyone debate, I felt the weighty responsibility of providing another clear-cut answer.

He’s acting suspicious, he looks vicious, and the men with him look like they’ve each got at least eighteen prior convictions.

No matter how I looked at it, only one solution came to mind.

“Prepare a volley.”

“Uh…?”

“Fire!”

Fwoosh, fwoosh, fwoosh!

[3622]The Yellow Turbans were rebels in late Han China, named for the yellow cloth they wore on their heads.

Chapter 1008

To cut to the chase, by the time the third volley of arrows ended, the leaders of Gansu Murim had decided to let the fifty-odd suspicious-looking men—including the giant—inside the gates.

Of course, it would be misleading to call it a decision made by the entire leadership. Jeok Cheongang's presence had a great deal to do with it.

"I don't know what hole these mangy mutts crawled out of, but let them in alive for now."

Then he added, addressing the murmuring leaders, "What are you agonizing over? If they seem suspicious, kill them and send them back out."

"Oh."

"Ah."

It was such a clear-cut answer that even Judge Bao[3623] would've brought his dog-headed execution blade down with a smack. The meeting that hardly deserved to be called a meeting came to an end, and the Black Night King, Sima Gong, immediately ordered his subordinates to admit the vicious-looking visitors.

Rumble, rumble.

The massive iron gates began to open, little by little.

The giant was the first to step through the gap. He swept his bulging eyes around him.

He'd damn near shit blood dodging three volleys of arrows, and now his clothes were practically rags. His half-rolled eyes darted about, searching for someone.

Someone like the young bastard who'd suddenly ordered the archers to fire.

"Looking for someone? Keep that up and you'll get a crick in your neck. Want me to find them for you?"

I'd come down first to greet our unexpected visitors. I tossed out the question as I stepped forward, and the giant's eyes widened.

"You, you…!"

"I saw it all from up there. Nice job blocking them. Nice job dodging, too."

"You look like a gisaeng's[3624] older brother, you bastard! How dare you!"

"What did you just call me?"

My expression hardened. At the unsettling pressure coming off me, the giant flinched on instinct, then forced out another strained reply.

[3623] Judge Bao is a legendary Chinese magistrate associated with execution blades bearing animal-head designs.

[3624] A *gisaeng* was a Korean female entertainer. Comparing a man to a gisaeng's older brother mocks his pretty face.

"I said you look like a gisaeng's[3625] older brother...!"

"Hold on. Just hold on a second."

"What?"

Leaving the giant's angry, baffled question hanging, I closed my eyes.

He said I look like a gisaeng's[3626] older brother.

What a wonderful thing to hear.

For a man of the same sex, with the same chromosomes, to say that to me was the highest praise imaginable.

I savored the lingering swell of emotion, then opened my eyes.

"Thanks. Turns out you're a good guy."

"...?"

"So, Junggeol, where are you from?"

"...!"

The giant—or rather, Ma Junggeol—nearly popped his eyes out of his head.

"How did you know?!"

"Hm? Know what?"

"My, my name."

Seeing him stumble over his words now, I answered as casually as could be.

"Didn't I tell you? We already introduced ourselves. You've forgotten that fast?"

"I...?"

"You must still be rattled. Fair enough. You had to dodge all those arrows."

Ma Junggeol would probably never know that, at this very moment, a translucent holographic window was floating like a ghost above his head.

> **System**
> **Level:** 80
> **Name:** Ma Junggeol

Level 80.

A person's level wasn't an absolute measure of their strength, but even so, it was awfully low for someone I'd suspect of being a Dark Heaven lackey.

Going by what I saw earlier, he's maybe a fairly seasoned Peak master?

Still, you couldn't let your guard down so easily.

As I slowly looked Ma Junggeol over, his expression still dazed, the leaders atop the wall finally came down the stairs, Jeok Cheongang among them.

[3625] A *gisaeng* was a Korean female entertainer. Comparing a man to a gisaeng's older brother mocks his pretty face.

[3626] A *gisaeng* was a Korean female entertainer. Comparing a man to a gisaeng's older brother mocks his pretty face.

At the same time, the fifty-odd mounted men came rushing toward us.

“Stop!”

“Let’s talk! Let’s talk!”

“We don’t want to fight!”

“Big Brother! Are you all right?”

“Enough!”

“I’m going to lose my mind. I told you to stop doing that.”

Six men, riding side by side at the very front of the group, surrounded Ma Junggeol.

What the hell are these guys?

I was sure everyone there was thinking much the same thing.

The lanky one. The dwarf. The bulbous-nosed one. The tiny-eyed one…

Every one of them had striking features that seemed to have gone their own way. You didn’t see a combination like that every day. And Ma Junggeol, standing in the middle of those six men, was the finishing touch.

Was his father Picasso?

They all had such strong impressionist faces that even the Black Dragon Demon Gate’s martial artists—who’d spent their share of time at the bottom—instinctively reached for their sword hilts.

Shing.

As the faint sounds of friction from here and there heightened the tension, a low voice reached everyone’s ears.

“I guarantee that anyone who tries something stupid from this point on will spend a very hot time with this old man.”

No one present needed to ask who’d spoken.

And, naturally, not even Tokyo Hot[3627] could hold a candle to the JCK-444 Fire Show Special. No one wanted to star in it.

Shuffle, shuffle.

The crowd parted to either side as though fleeing a fire demon.

Jeok Cheongang emerged through the gap, leading the other leaders. He glanced at Ma Junggeol, then turned to me.

“So, who is he, and where did he come from?”

“His name is Ma Junggeol. I don’t know where he came from yet.”

“Could he be a Dark Heaven lackey?”

“We’d have to beat the truth out of him to be sure. But, as you already know, he doesn’t look or seem capable of pulling anything clever…”

[3627] Tokyo Hot is a Japanese adult-video studio.

“You can’t judge by a feeling alone. What do you think of the possibility that they’re deliberately hiding their strength?”

Jeok Cheongang wasn’t asking because he didn’t know. He meant for everyone listening to our conversation to hear the question. Once I understood his intent, I answered without hesitation.

“No chance.”

“You must have a reason for thinking so.”

“Old—no, Master, if they were strong enough to fool you and the others here, they’d have to have undergone at least Returning to Simplicity or Bone Transformation.”

“And?”

“Look at those faces. Supreme Peak masters who’d reached that level couldn’t possibly look like that.”

“…!”

“…!”

The seven terrifying-looking men, Ma Junggeol included, shuddered. What could I do? It was true.

I’d suddenly found myself playing lawyer, and I felt an inexplicable sense of duty as I continued.

“Therefore, I find no grounds to charge them with ‘vicious-looking men concealing their martial arts,‘ and I rest my case.”

Jeok Cheongang nodded with an expression of admiration.

“Your argument is so logical that even this old man hardly dares to dispute it.”

“Thank you.”

“But looking at those faces—whether they’re Yellow Turbans,[3628] Dark Heaven, or men who’ve held important posts in the Demonic Cult at the very least—I can’t help but find them suspicious.”

“So what are you going to do?”

“Either they confess everything right now, or I’ll beat it out of them with the Flame Divine Palm.”

His voice was directed at me, but his gaze wasn’t.

Under Jeok Cheongang’s stare, which seemed to pour streams of fire, Ma Junggeol went pale and stammered, “A-are you really the Fire King, Great Hero Jeok Cheongang…?”

Jeok Cheongang replied with a bored look.

“Of course I’m real. Did you think I was a fake?”

[3628] The Yellow Turbans were a rebel movement in late Han-dynasty China.

“If that’s true, then the gisaeng’s[3629] older brother—no, the young man—is the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon…”

It was my turn to speak.

Smiling broadly at hearing that pleasant description again, I tried to reassure the terrified Ma Junggeol.

“Keep calling me a gisaeng’s[3630] older brother. Make yourself comfortable. Come to think of it, I was rude, speaking so casually to you all this time. I’m sorry. Okay?”

“N-no, that’s all right. But it seems there’s been a misunderstanding for a while now. May I say something to clear it up?”

“Now you’re talking. You should’ve said—spoken up sooner.”

“I was trying to explain, but you jumped straight to—”

“Go on, then. Skip the preamble.”

At my gentle but forceful urging, Ma Junggeol hesitated, then straightened his shoulders and cautiously addressed the leaders, Jeok Cheongang included.

“To cut to the chase, we came from Ningxia.”

“Hold on. Ningxia? Could you be…?”

A thought crossed my mind, and I frowned. Ma Junggeol hurriedly added, “We’re not mounted bandits!”

Jeok Cheongang muttered, “So that’s why their faces looked suspicious. They’re those mounted bandits who’ve been spreading filth all over Ningxia Province.”

“I-it’s true that I belonged to a band of mounted bandits for a short time, but that’s not who we are now…”

Just then, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord cut in, eyeing Ma Junggeol and his men with narrowed eyes.

“Infinite Life Buddha.[3631] I shouldn’t say this as a man who pursues the Way, but as Senior Jeok said, those faces clearly belong to men still in the trade.”

People nodded here and there in agreement.

Then, as if to prove why looks ruled modern society, the mood slowly turned hostile. One person spoke up.

“Ma Junggeol, Ma Junggeol… Could you be that very Ma Junggeol of Baekma Bang?”

It was the Black Night King, Sima Gong.

He’d been deep in thought with his brow furrowed. At his question, Ma Junggeol and his men—whose faces had been turning more and more sallow—visibly brightened.

[3629] A *gisaeng* was a Korean female entertainer. Comparing a man to a gisaeng’s older brother mocks his pretty face.

[3630] A *gisaeng* was a Korean female entertainer. Comparing a man to a gisaeng’s older brother mocks his pretty face.

[3631] “Infinite Life Buddha” is a Buddhist invocation referring to Amitabha, the Buddha of Infinite Life.

“Y-you know me?”

“I’ve heard of you through the grapevine. More than ten years ago, an unknown master pacified the mounted-bandit gangs in Ningxia Province. A few of their leaders changed their ways under his guidance, joined forces, and founded a horse caravan.”

“That’s right! That’s me—or rather, that’s us!”

As though he’d finally found someone he could talk to, Ma Junggeol’s color returned. His expression grew serious as he saluted everyone with clasped hands.

“I am Ma Junggeol, Chief of Baekma Bang. The Seven Masters of Baekma Bang greet the heroes of the Murim Alliance.”

“…?”

“…?”

A suffocating silence pressed in from all sides.

The elegant title didn’t fit their vicious faces at all. The leaders and I silently exchanged glances, while the six men, prompted belatedly by Ma Junggeol, awkwardly copied his salute and whispered among themselves.

“Uh, is this how you do the salute, hyungs?[3632]”

“You idiot. How many times have I told you to cover your left hand with your right palm?”

“What are you talking about? The youngest did it right. Fourth Hyung’s[3633] the one doing it wrong.”

“Oh, you’re right…”

“Enough! Can’t you all shut up? Do you know what kind of place this is?”

“Sheesh. A minute ago you were shouting ‘Enough! Enough!‘ at the top of your lungs. Now you lower your voice because there are masters around. Being born later is my fucking crime. My crime.”

“…”

What the hell was going on with these guys?

Their voices were low, but their conversation still came through clearly. Everyone’s eyes went flat. Only Sima Gong kept his composure as he spoke.

“Yes, I’ve heard about Baekma Bang a few times. I hear you’ve fought off the nomads who invaded through the northern Great Steppe and given plenty of help to the commoners who’ve begun settling there. But…”

Sima Gong let his voice trail off. His gaze suddenly sharpened.

“What brings you here so abruptly?”

[3632] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him; *hyungs* is its English plural.

[3633] *Hyung* is a Korean form of address used by a man for an older brother or an older man close to him; *hyungs* is its English plural.

With everyone’s attention on him, Ma Junggeol straightened his bent back and answered.

“We came here to offer our help.”

“Help with what?”

“Dark Heaven. We have important information about them.”

“…!”

Chapter 1009

If Ma Junggeol had given even the slightest suspicious or flimsy reason, he would've been thrown straight back out the gate—or stuffed into the underground prison somewhere inside the city to have a long chat with the torture specialists.

But when he lowered his voice, the reason he gave was more important than I'd expected.

"Dark Heaven. I have important information about them."

"…!"

The moment he said it, everyone among the leadership, myself included, realized our unwelcome visitors might be a lot more useful than we'd thought.

"Well, we've kept our distinguished guests standing outside for far too long. Why don't you come in for a cup of tea?"

At Sima Gong's subtle invitation, Ma Junggeol straightened his shoulders as though nothing had happened and nodded.

"Sounds good. Just so you know, of all the teas, my brothers and I favor grain tea most."

"I heard the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang were renowned drinkers. You're every bit as forthright as they say. Come on in, then."

Important conversations were best held with as few people watching as possible.

A few moments later, Ma Junggeol and his six men—no, the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang—had gone from unwelcome visitors to honored guests, each with a seat in the grand meeting hall.

"Ahhh. That's good."

Starting with Ma Junggeol, his six sworn brothers drained a small wine jar in one go, then smacked their lips.

"Whew, that's really something."

"What kind of liquor is this? It just melts on your tongue."

"Right? It's insane."

"…It's liquor. Of course it does. What the hell do you mean, 'melts'? This is why people call you an idiot."

"Enough! Fourth, is that any way to speak to your brothers?"

"Whew, look at you raising your voice again the second you can breathe easy. Honestly, I'd like to crack this wine jar over the back of your head right now."

Naturally, no one's head met the wine jar.

That was thanks to one remark from Jeok Cheongang, who'd been silently watching the seven-colored mounted-bandit rangers—or rather, the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang.

"Did you come here to drink?"

"…!"

"…!"

"You've wet your throats. Now, go on and spit it out."

Ma Junggeol flinched at the menacing aura rolling off Jeok Cheongang, then stammered out a reply.

"F-first, I assume you already know something about the situation in Ningxia."

"I've heard the basics. Because of mounted bandits like you, the place nearly became a battlefield, but it's been quiet for the past few years. Is that right?"

"We're no longer mounted bandits, but yes. Great Hero Jeok is right."

"Still look like a bunch of mounted bandits to this old man, but go on."

"There've been a few minor disputes over the years, but it's become a fairly livable place. Anyone who'd done something they might feel guilty about left long ago. The ones who remain have completely turned over a new leaf and live ordinary lives, like me and my brothers. Sect Leader Sima here knows this well, too."

Everyone's eyes turned to Sima Gong. He nodded calmly.

"It's true. As Ningxia Province settled down, various merchant caravans began passing through, and we heard all sorts of things from them. That was when I first heard about Baekma Bang."

With Sima Gong backing him up, Ma Junggeol quickly picked up the thread.

"I don't know exactly what you heard, Sect Leader Sima, but Baekma Bang is by far the largest group in Ningxia Province. Recently, we've even been opening a new trade route to help Ningxia Province prosper."

"Wait. This new trade route you mentioned—is it perhaps…?"

"It's probably where you're thinking."

Surprise spread across Sima Gong's face. Watching him, I had a sudden thought.

"West. You mean west."

"…!"

My sudden words sent an invisible ripple through the room.

Naturally. The west I meant wasn't Gansu or Qinghai.

"Xinjiang…"

The word slipped through the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's lips like a groan.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword and the Roaring Fury Swordsman had been watching Ma Junggeol with obvious disapproval for a while now, as though something about him rubbed them the wrong way. They frowned and spoke up, too.

"So that's what this is about. Xinjiang, huh. Hah."

"I can't listen to this anymore. How long are we supposed to sit here listening to such ridiculous nonsense?"

Much as I hated to admit it, theirs was the reasonable reaction.

What kind of place was Xinjiang?

It was even called the Land of Ruin.

A cursed land of endless deserts, teeming with Fiends who proclaimed the world belonged to the Demonic Path.

And a mere horse-caravan group—not one of the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families—was supposed to open a trade route to Xinjiang?

What a joke.

And yet I could feel my heart beginning to beat faster.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword and the Roaring Fury Swordsman had forgotten the most important thing.

This wasn't a pitch for investment or a business presentation.

Ma Junggeol's story wasn't over. The real story was only just beginning.

"That's enough preamble, isn't it?"

Jeok Cheongang's low question left no doubt what he meant. Ma Junggeol drew a deep breath and spoke again.

"Even after things settled down, Ningxia Province was still in bad shape. The land was barren, and the nomads from the Great Steppe along our border raided us every harvest season. We needed a new way out."

"So you wanted to cross the desert and open a trade route?"

"That was the idea, but it was nothing more than a dream. Even an uneducated fool like me knew people like us had no business dreaming of something so far beyond our reach. But…"

Ma Junggeol's gaze suddenly shifted toward me.

"Not long ago, an opportunity came out of nowhere. The many nomads occupying the western Great Steppe suddenly began a mass migration."

"Jamukha."

The name slipped from my lips before I could stop it.

Only then did I understand why Ma Junggeol was looking at me, and what he'd meant by an unexpected opportunity.

Jamukha's massive army had controlled the western steppe. They'd taken almost all their forces and marched into Shanxi Province. The gap they left behind had given Baekma Bang its chance.

"Then were you trying to reach Xinjiang through the steppe?"

At my question, gasps came from around the room.

Of course. There was another route, one so obvious now that everyone had forgotten it.

To the people of the Central Plains, the Great Steppe had long been another forbidden land, just like Xinjiang. But it was also the fastest shortcut across the desert.

Under everyone's gaze, Ma Junggeol nodded, his face tense.

"That's right."

"…!"

"I picked out the men under me who were good riders, and we kept driving our horses without stopping. After riding like mad for ten whole days, we finally saw a vast yellow stretch of land in the distance. We'd reached the desert."

Just then, his six sworn brothers, who'd been keeping an eye on everyone's reaction behind him, nodded and chimed in.

"Man, it was a real shitshow. Honestly, I wanted to say to hell with the Chief and the whole damn venture and turn back."

"But what could we do? We'd already come that far. We figured we might as well set foot on the sand before going home."

"Then we traveled another ten days or so, right?"

"Don't remind me. Even now, just thinking about that goddamn desert makes my knees buckle."

"Enough! What a bunch of weaklings. Even through all that hardship, I trusted Big Brother and followed him."

The diminutive middle-aged man, who looked rather old, delivered a stern rebuke. The man with the bulbous nose snorted.

"They say even if a horse's hooves go crooked, you should keep the reins straight. So at least get your story straight. What did you do the moment those black bastards showed up on the tenth day, Second Hyung[3634]? You didn't even look back. You got ready to run."

"Enough…!"

The dwarf's face turned as red as a ripe persimmon. He lunged at the bulbous-nosed man, but I was much faster.

Snatch.

His small fist landed squarely in my grasp.

I'd caught the dwarf's punch with ridiculous ease. I fixed the bulbous-nosed man with a cold stare.

"Say that again."

"W-what?"

"You just said those black bastards appeared on the tenth day after you entered the desert."

He'd said it in passing, but everyone in the room had heard him clearly.

And the moment we heard it, our suspicion turned to certainty.

"It was Dark Heaven."

Ma Junggeol spoke up in place of the bulbous-nosed man and continued.

"There were only a few dozen of them, but I'm certain. I'll stake my life on it."

[3634] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male he is close to.

Sima Gong spoke in a grave voice.

“What makes you so certain?”

“We followed them.”

“What?”

“For a day and a half. That was the best we could do. But I saw it with my own eyes. That night, when the moon was unusually bright, at least a thousand tents covered the sand dunes.”

“…!”

“There’s only one force in the western desert that could mobilize an army that large. Dark Heaven. Isn’t that right?”

A cold silence filled the meeting hall instead of an answer.

A thousand. Not a thousand people—a thousand *tents*.

What’s more, Ma Junggeol’s route across the desert was clearly closer to Gansu than Qinghai.

Even by the lowest estimate, that meant thousands, perhaps tens of thousands, of enemies were targeting Gansu Province.

And that might not even be all of them.

My mind went cold. Meanwhile, my heartbeat had grown so fast it was thundering in my ears.

Of course, it was too soon to be certain. There was still a question I needed answered before making a decision.

“You’re lucky you made it back alive.”

Sima Gong’s low voice broke the silence. Under his unfathomable gaze, Ma Junggeol licked his parched lips.

“It was close. I thought my heart was going to burst.”

“You know what I mean. Are you pretending not to?”

“We followed at a distance of exactly a hundred li.[3635] The beginning was hard, but after that, their numbers kept growing, which made it much easier.”

“A mere horse caravan followed Dark Heaven without being spotted? Is that possible?”

“I’m ashamed to say it, but we’re not an ordinary horse caravan, are we? We may not wear our hair in queues, but when it comes to riding and keeping a sharp eye out, we’re no different from the nomads.”

“You could have turned back as soon as you spotted them. Why follow them for another day and a half?”

“That… well…”

Ma Junggeol hesitated, glanced at Sima Gong, then answered cautiously.

[3635] In the Chinese setting, one *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi); a hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi).

“I’d heard that if you render a service for the good of the realm, no one holds your origins against you.”

“You were thinking about a reward?”

“Yes.”

They’d managed it because there were few enough of them to avoid notice, and because their years as mounted bandits had taught them how to survive.

Their reason was clear, too.

After a moment’s thought, I turned to Jeok Cheongang and spoke.

“Now we know for sure which battlefield we need to be on.”

Chapter 1010

"So, that's what you've decided?"

At Jeok Cheongang's question, I nodded.

"Yes. I think I need to stay here after all."

If Ma Junggeol and his men had arrived half a day later, I'd probably already be on my way to Qinghai with the Fire Dragon Pavilion members.

Gansu had enough forces as things stood.

The Kongtong Sect and the Zhongnan Sect.

Two towering powers of the Nine Sects and One Gang stood firm here, and the Black Dragon Demon Gate, led by Sima Gong, was every bit their equal.

The dark-path figures and unorthodox factions gathered under the Black Dragon Demon Gate might have been inferior in quality, but their sheer numbers made them an enormous force.

But now the situation had changed.

The massive Dark Heaven army—estimated to number at least tens of thousands—was a problem. But the biggest reason I'd decided to stay in Gansu was time.

The time it would take them to reach us.

"When exactly did you return to Ningxia?"

Ma Junggeol answered.

"Three days ago. We arrived in the middle of the night, so I suppose you could say it was two days ago."

"Three days ago?"

Jeok Cheongang cut in abruptly, furrowing his brow. Ma Junggeol hurriedly continued.

"W-we were facing an emergency ourselves. We were so busy sending urgent messages throughout Ningxia and getting our men moving that we barely had time to think."

He'd apparently taken Jeok Cheongang's reaction to mean, *You arrived three days ago, so why are you only coming to us now?* But I knew why Jeok Cheongang had frowned.

That was right around the time.

A memory suddenly came to mind.

Several hundred people, trembling with fear, had said mounted bandits were roaming not far away.

Ningxia Province must still have seemed lawless to them. With Ma Junggeol's urgent message causing an uproar, they'd probably mistaken the commotion for a mounted-bandit attack.

It had all happened so recently that even the Lower District Sect member from the Shaanxi branch hadn't known the details.

So that's what it was.

Things come around, and everything connects.

The outcome of one incident becomes the beginning of another, until eventually it all leads here.

And Ma Junggeol's answer—that they'd arrived three days ago—gave everyone plenty to think about.

"How long did it take you to get back?"

At the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's question, Ma Junggeol counted on his fingers.

"Let's see. It took seven days and nights just to get out of the desert, and crossing the grasslands again took a day longer than that… About a month, I'd say."

"Wait. Didn't you say earlier that it took twenty days just to get there? And then you spent another day and a half following Dark Heaven."

"That's right. But traveling a route for the first time isn't the same as taking it on the way back. Do you think we're mounted bandits—no, horse caravans—for nothing?"

"…Hmm."

It was hard to argue with that.

Just as the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, a Supreme Peak master, could judge an opponent's level and the kind of martial arts they practiced from only a few forms, no one could match mounted bandits and horse caravans at finding the fastest route.

"Too much caution can be its own poison. There's something more important here."

Jeok Cheongang stopped the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord before he could respond and fixed his gaze on Ma Junggeol.

"If you were leading an army of tens of thousands, how long would it take you to reach here?"

"W-well…"

Ma Junggeol thought hard for a moment, then sighed.

"That's hard to answer. But…"

"But?"

"Assuming they had enough camels, desert horses, and supplies—and every last one of them knew enough martial arts to endure a grueling forced march… Yes. Even with delays, a month at most."

"One month. Just a month."

"Of course, depending on the circumstances, it could be much shorter."

Ma Junggeol glanced around as he added that last part. Sima Gong's face stiffened.

"What circumstances do you mean?"

"Have you forgotten? We lost more time than necessary crossing the grasslands. Where we spotted them wasn't all that far from Gansu. Even taking that enormous force into account…"

Ma Junggeol trailed off. He swallowed hard before continuing.

"A-about twenty days should be enough."

"…!"

"…!"

The air in the meeting room turned cold.

No—it froze like a glacier.

His words reminded everyone of a fact they'd briefly forgotten. They stared at one another, eyes wide.

That was right.

Unlike Ma Junggeol, who'd had to hurry back the way he came, Dark Heaven had another option.

They could advance.

Instead of detouring across the grasslands, they could break through the front by sheer force.

And if they chose a direct assault, there would be precious little time left before the fighting began.

One day, or maybe two.

Of course, that was the worst-case scenario.

No one knew whether Dark Heaven's army had stayed there for several more days after Ma Junggeol left—or whether they were still there now.

But we had to plan for the worst.

That was war.

"I think we can throw any more armchair strategizing out the window. Don't you all agree?"

Over Jeok Cheongang's low voice, which broke the silence, rang a clear chime that didn't fit the situation at all.

Ding.

Rumble, rumble.

Was this what a small mountain would look like in motion?

With the Black Dragon Demon Gate, the Zhongnan Sect, and the hundreds of martial artists Sima Gong had conscripted from nearby, our force had grown to

more than two thousand—close to three thousand. I looked at the endless wave of people and horses stretching out behind me, then raised my eyes to the air.

More precisely, to the translucent holographic window floating there.

> **System**
> The conditions for the current Quest have been met!
> **Head West** — Complete
> Quest **Desert Mirage** successfully completed!
> Quest rewards have been granted!
> Gained a large amount of EXP and Fame!
> A new linked Quest has been generated upon completion of **Desert Mirage**.
> Would you like to view the new Quest?

Barely half an hour.

That was an impossibly short time for an army of nearly three thousand to finish its preparations and set out. I certainly hadn't had a chance to check the newly generated linked Quest.

Not that I needed to check it right away. I had a rough idea what it would say.

I adjusted my grip on the reins of my galloping horse and gave the command in my head.

Open Quest window.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Quest
Road of Blood
Long ago, this land was a trade route linking one continent to another. Today, it has fallen into grave peril.
The foreign merchants with their unfamiliar features are gone. So are those who crossed the desert for foreign lands with wagons piled high with silk.
The rulers of the vast desert have cut off the trade route that once brought prosperity to the Central Plains. Now they want everything within the Great Wall.
The old days, when silk flowed in abundance, have become a distant, dusty past.
Steel without end, blood, and corpses will be the present and future of this land.
May fortune be with you.
Grade: Supreme Peak
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: Annihilate enemy forces in the Gansu region — Incomplete
Reward: A large amount of EXP and Fame
Linked Quest based on your choice
Failure: Dark Heaven wins
— Lose control of the Gansu region

As expected.

It was more or less what I'd anticipated.

Actually, I knew full well that if we failed, it wouldn't end there.

If the Gansu front collapses, the entire west will be in danger.

War was like a line of dominoes.

No matter how carefully and thoroughly you prepared from beginning to end, one mistake could bring everything you'd built crashing down in an instant.

We have to stop them before it's too late.

At least Gansu Murim had prepared thoroughly.

Three successive defensive lines, with thirty thousand troops deployed according to each line's importance.

Dunhuang, the foremost of those three lines, was close enough to reach within three days if we pushed ourselves to the limit.

The Silk Road.

Better known by that name to people in the modern world, this region was an endless stretch of plains and wilderness.

There was no narrow path to slow us down, no terrain so rugged we'd have to abandon our horses.

We just had to ride until the horses collapsed from exhaustion.

The problem was…

Dark Heaven could do the same.

That was why we couldn't afford to lose even a moment.

Even with camels and desert horses, there was a limit to how fast they could travel through the desert. But once they reached land covered in soil and grass instead of sand, that would change.

Dunhuang would be the first domino to fall, and tens of thousands of enemies would soon swarm across Gansu like locusts—

"What are you staring at so intently?"

"…!"

"Checking the shape of the clouds or something?"

I wasn't exaggerating when I said I nearly jumped out of my skin.

It wasn't the sudden voice that startled me. It was the menacing face that filled my vision the moment I turned my head.

"Ah, damn. You scared me. What's with you all of a sudden?"

Ma Junggeol answered, sitting as comfortably as ever on his violently bouncing saddle. A former mounted bandit and current horse-caravan chief through and through.

"Nothing much. You've been staring into the air for a while, so I thought I'd talk to you."

"What's it to you where I'm looking? And I don't think we're close enough to be chatting."

"Of course we're not. You're the one who had them rain arrows down on me. Three times, no less."

His already vicious face twisted into a scowl. I answered flatly.

"So?"

"…You've got no conscience, do you? And even if I can understand the first two times, what on earth were you thinking when you ordered them to fire the third?"

"Just thought stopping at two would make me look cold."

"…?"

"That's it. Happy?"

At my offhand answer, Ma Junggeol gaped at me as if I were insane.

"What do you mean, 'that's it'? Are you even human?"

"Feels like that's a question I should be asking you."

"…What's that supposed to mean?"

What did it mean? He knew perfectly well.

But I was too tenderhearted to hit him with the facts about his looks.

I silently shrugged. Looking at Ma Junggeol, I had another thought.

Still, he really is nothing like he looks.

Judging by his face alone, he looked like some evil spirit who could plunge the world into ruin. But from the way he acted, and the bits of his personality that showed through now and then, he seemed surprisingly stupid.

Even now, at the strong insistence of a few leaders who still suspected Ma Junggeol and the other horse-caravan men, he was practically being held hostage. Yet he seemed utterly carefree.

Chapter 1011

Suspecting someone was hardly a good thing.

But in a time of war, suspicion was another word for caution.

The longer and more closely you looked, the clearer the truth became—and the closer you came to victory.

That was the main reason Ma Junggeol and the other six members of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang had joined our party.

Or, to be precise, the Fire Dragon Pavilion I led.

Though I was the one who volunteered to take them.

They were originally supposed to be placed under Sima Gong's watch. But when I pointed out that he already had a sizable force to command, the decision came quickly.

They would be assigned to the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Time was so short that no one raised any further objections. Still, I saw it clearly.

The moment the decision about the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang was made, Sima Gong's eyes sank deeper than before.

Am I imagining it? Or…

I let the thought trail off and glanced at Ma Junggeol.

He'd been grumbling about how rude it was to ignore someone standing right in front of you, but at some point he'd gone quiet.

Or so it seemed.

Thud-thud-thud!

Hooves thundered beneath us. A fierce wind wrapped around my body and rushed past.

And through it all…

Wooooong.

A faint ripple reached me, almost hidden by the noise.

This is…

I knew it instinctively. It was a flow of qi only someone who had reached a profound realm could sense.

Buried beneath the pounding hooves and rushing wind, that faint ripple carried a voice I had never heard before.

Ssshhh.

I hadn't reasoned it out. This was an instinct I'd forgotten for a moment.

Like a child just discovering he could stand on two feet, I sent my qi toward the ripple emanating from Ma Junggeol.

It touched, mingled with, and became one with the ripple.

So naturally that even Ma Junggeol, its source, didn't notice.

The same went for the ripples his six sworn brothers were exchanging nearby.

"…long do we have to be dragged along like this?"

The faint ripple—no, the Sound Transmission—rang clearly in my ears at last.

Ding.

SYSTEM

Hidden achievement A Bug in My Ear achieved! You can now detect and eavesdrop on nearby Sound Transmissions! This is another ability granted to those who reach a great realm. But don't get too excited. The Sound Transmissions you can eavesdrop on are limited by the levels of both the target and the user!

…So I can do this now.

I blinked in a daze, then focused on the Sound Transmissions reaching my ears.

Let's hear what they're plotting.

"Honestly, how long do we have to be dragged along like this?"

"Exactly. What are we, hostages?"

"Whew, Father. I miss you so much today."

"Huh? Didn't your father pass away more than twenty years ago?"

"That's why I miss him even more."

"Oh."

Ma Junggeol answered his younger brothers' grumbling Sound Transmissions sternly.

"Now, now. Why are you all complaining? We expected this from the start."

The second brother, who fled faster than anyone in an emergency but worshipped the Chief like the heavens the rest of the time, nodded.

"Enough! The Chief is a hundred, a thousand times right, so all of you shut up. If he hadn't foreseen this from the beginning, would he have dragged us into such a deathtrap?"

That was the second brother for you.

There was a reason people said no younger brother could outdo his older brother.

Ma Junggeol smiled with satisfaction as the little man gently put the others in their place.

"Didn't you hear what the Chief said earlier?"

The third brother, who always had to stick his foot in, broke in. The second blinked.

“Earlier? When?”

“Right before we left. He went off by himself, supposedly to check a perfectly good saddle, and started muttering under his breath. I listened, and…”

“And?”

“No, there’s nothing to hear. It was nothing, so don’t worry about it.”

Ma Junggeol remembered what had happened half a shichen[3636] earlier and hurried to cut him off. But the third brother’s Sound Transmission was already riding the wind.

“We’re fucked. What do we do now?”

“…”

“…”

A wind colder than the bitter north wind swept through the group.

In the heavy silence, six pairs of eyes bored mercilessly into the back of Ma Junggeol’s head. His gaze darkened.

“Chief…”

“Third Brother, is that true?”

“It’s not, is it? It isn’t, right?”

“If that’s true, then seriously…”

“E-enough! There’s no way the Chief would say that.”

“What do you mean, ‘there’s no way’? I heard him with my own ears.”

At a loss for words, Ma Junggeol’s eyes darted back and forth.

How was he supposed to answer? He’d never dreamed anyone would hear the words he’d let slip—least of all the third brother.

“That, well…”

Unable to stay silent forever, he sent a hesitant reply.

His six quick-witted brothers groaned at once.

“So it’s true.”

“It really is.”

“Ah, Mother. I want to see you so badly today.”

“Sometimes it’s like that. When someone passed away long ago, you miss them all the more.”

“Are you crazy? She’s still perfectly healthy. Why are you killing her off?”

“Oh.”

“Enough…!”

[3636] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“Chief, what are we actually going to do? At this rate, they’ll drag us all the way to the front and use us to catch swords, won’t they?”

Unlike the others, who had descended into confusion, the third brother was at least facing reality. Ma Junggeol gave the faintest shake of his head.

“Don’t worry. Things are going a little—just a little—worse than I expected, but they won’t use us to catch swords like you said.”

“If it’s not swords, it’ll be arrows. Thanks, Chief. You’ve ruined all our lives.”

“Now, now. I said that won’t happen!”

“What makes you so sure? Let’s be blunt. If they give us an order, we’re in no position to refuse.”

“Well…”

“Look around. There are already several Supreme Peak masters here—people you’d be lucky to see once in your life. If those monsters start prodding us in the back and giving us the look, what choice do guys like us have except to run out and fight like hell?”

The third brother’s Sound Transmission poured out with pent-up anger. His sworn brothers joined in.

“There are those Zhongnan Sect Daoist punks treating us like outright bandits, the Black Night King himself, the Fire King, and that young Disciple of his who looks half-mad.”

“Especially that Jin Taekyung right in front of the Chief. He’s not right in the head. Have you forgotten how we nearly crossed the Sanzu River[3637] before we’d even made it through the gate?”

“Damn it, is this why we quit being mounted bandits? I’ll admit our past wasn’t exactly something to brag about, but we quit before we’d even gotten to rob anyone! We spent all day, every day sharpening our swords and never even got to draw them.”

“Enough! Now that I think about it, this is downright unfair. Have we robbed anyone? Killed any innocent civilians? We’d only just made up our minds to pull off one good score when we met Great Sir and turned over a new leaf. We’re trying to live decent lives, and this is what we get?”

“Second Brother’s right. Sure, we look like this, but if we’d gone around doing only the most vicious things like everyone else, do you think Great Sir would’ve left us alone? Isn’t that right?”

Their Sound Transmissions were full of wounded indignation. Listening to them, Ma Junggeol felt a pang in his own heart.

They were right. What had they done wrong?

[3637] The Sanzu River is a Buddhist river said to lie between the world of the living and the afterlife.

He couldn’t deny that they used to be mounted bandits. But he could swear to heaven that they’d never done anything deserving punishment.

If we had, at least this treatment wouldn’t feel so unfair.

Robbing civilians?

Even when they steeled themselves and rode out to attack, they couldn’t bring themselves to do it.

What could they take from people other mounted bandits had already stripped bare? Countless times, they’d given food instead to families holding newborns too hungry to cry.

And that wasn’t all.

They might have looked like fiends, but Ma Junggeol and his six sworn brothers were timid by nature.

Robbing or killing civilians had been impossible for them from the start. And even when they occasionally came across a gutsy merchant caravan traveling to Ningxia Province, they just collected a toll and let it pass.

Why?

Simple.

Because they were scared.

Who would travel through a lawless place like Ningxia Province without a proper escort?

It was only natural for an Escort Bureau or merchant caravan to bring at least several dozen armed men. In that tense standoff, Ma Junggeol just had to put on his vicious face and say:

“So, you mean to shed blood after all?”

A face to rival any fiend’s, paired with a stern voice, made an excellent way to talk things over.

Whether the other party was an Escort Bureau, a merchant caravan, or a mounted-bandit group so practiced at killing that they were nearly ready to ascend to immortality.

That was how Ma Junggeol and his six sworn brothers had survived as mounted bandits back when their martial arts were still rudimentary.

Until the man they called Great Sir appeared.

Even now, Ma Junggeol firmly believed in Great Sir, who had led them onto the right path.

“Enough, all of you!”

At his forceful Sound Transmission, the complaints streaming from behind him stopped at once.

Ma Junggeol seized the brief opening.

“There’s nothing to worry about. Set me aside—surely Great Sir anticipated a situation like this?”

“Hmm.”

“That’s true.”

“The Chief might not have, but Great Sir is different.”

“Right. We can’t trust the Chief, but we can trust Great Sir.”

“Now that you mention it, that makes sense.”

“For once, you’re saying something right.”

The answers only made him feel stranger the longer he thought about them, but Ma Junggeol continued his Sound Transmission with a vague sense of unease.

“I sent a few men back on the pretext of relaying news to Ningxia, so Great Sir will hear about this. Until then, don’t do anything rash. Understood?”

The third brother, the one with the bulbous nose, cut in.

“But that’s only if Great Sir’s in his right mind.”

“What?”

“Well, isn’t it? You know as well as anyone how he can be a little… all over the place.”

Ma Junggeol blinked a few times, then stammered out a reply.

“H-he’ll be fine. Probably.”

Even without his uncertain answer, his sworn brothers knew no one could be sure of that.

“Damn. Now that Third Brother’s said it, I’ve got a bad feeling.”

“But hasn’t Great Sir been more or less all right lately? That’s why he’s been telling us where to go from here and all that.”

“He has. But with him, you never know when he’ll snap.”

“Great Sir was strange from the first time we met him. His hair was a tangled mess, and his face was so black with grime you’d think he hadn’t washed in days. He looked like a beggar. Still does.”

“This is bad. If Great Sir’s out of it right now, sending the men to him won’t do any good, will it?”

As his sworn brothers’ worry deepened, Ma Junggeol scrunched up his already ugly face and thought hard. At last, he spoke.

“We have no choice. One of us should go in person. Maybe seeing a familiar face will help him come to his senses sooner.”

“One of us? Who?”

“Hard to say. We’ll have to decide now.”

“And once we do, how are you going to send him? That’ll be difficult right now.”

“As the Chief, I’ll take care of that, so don’t worry—wait a minute.”

Ma Junggeol abruptly stopped his Sound Transmission and frowned.

“You’ve been awfully casual with me for a while now. Did you lose half your tongue or something? Which insolent bastard is it? Huh?”

At that very moment, an actual voice he hadn’t expected reached his ears.

“Me.”

“…?”

“It’s me.”

No. Impossible. Surely not.

Muttering to himself, Ma Junggeol slowly raised his head. He’d been keeping it slightly lowered to hide his moving lips.

There, facing him, was that insolent bastard, smiling menacingly.

“Uh, uhh.”

Ma Junggeol shuddered as if possessed by a ghost. Jin Taekyung smiled warmly at him.

“Looks like there’s a lot you need to tell me. Isn’t that right?”

Chapter 1012

Time swept by like the wind as the horses galloped without rest.

The sunset swallowed the wilderness, and the darkness that followed pressed down on the world. Then a dim dawn crept in between them.

By the time darkness fell for the second time, Ma Junggeol's lips, which had been moving nonstop, could finally rest.

"…And that's what happened."

By the end of his long story, Ma Junggeol looked as though he'd aged overnight.

He'd spent more than a full day recounting everything that had happened over the past decade or so. But I suspected the audience—growing one person at a time, starting with me—had taken an even greater toll.

Especially the pressure radiating from the giant known as the Fire King.

"What do you mean, 'that's what happened'? Keep talking."

At Jeok Cheongang's low growl, Ma Junggeol, already exhausted, looked ready to cry.

"I really am finished. I'm telling you, there's nothing else to say."

"If I dig around and something else comes out, it's ten hits per syllable. Still nothing?"

"What?"

It wasn't as if he had a stash of stories hidden away. What was there to dig for?

Ma Junggeol gave me a pleading look. I shook my head and spoke up.

"Give it a rest. And why would he say anything if it's a hundred hits per syllable? Even if he had more to tell, he'd hold out to the death."

"Is that so? Then I'll lower it to ten. Spill everything."

"Ten would still kill him."

"Fine. One hit. That's this old man's final offer."

"…You might as well tell him to make his last will. At this point, it seems like you just want to kill him."

Jeok Cheongang frowned at my quiet objection.

"You're too soft. Sometimes you have to squeeze a man to get even one more word out of him."

"Look at him. You couldn't squeeze a drop of broth out of him now."

I wasn't exaggerating. Ma Junggeol looked as if half his soul had left his body.

Think about it.

Ten years was easy to say. But he'd had to recall, in detail and without a wink of sleep, everything that had happened over a span long enough for mountains and rivers to change. No wonder he'd turned into a half-dried squid in just over a day.

“P-please believe me. I really told you everything. I didn’t leave a thing out.”

Ma Junggeol pleaded with tears in his eyes, and his six sworn brothers opened their mouths to back him up.

Or rather, they started to.

“What Eldest Brother said is righ—”

“Shut your mouths before I beat you. Especially you.”

The short one Jeok Cheongang had singled out froze.

“M-me?”

“Yes, you. Chatter like that one more time and you’re dead. Do you have to chime in after every sentence, you little brat?”

The short one clamped his mouth shut. Watching from beside him, the bulbous-nosed one murmured with delight.

“Finally…”

Finally what?

None of these men seemed quite right in the head, but one thing was clear.

“Mujin.”

Hyuk Mujin understood what I meant and clicked his tongue. The other members reacted much the same way, apart from Sama Pyo and Taishan, who’d joined us the day before along with the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

“Tsk. Is this really okay? It doesn’t sit right with me.”

“Benefactor—no, Young Master Jin—no, Pavilion Master.”

“I think we should at least tie them up.”

“I see it differently—damn it, this miserable saddle!”

Unlike Taishan’s shoulders, which were as comfortable as a cushioned seat, Namho was perched on a saddle that bounced violently beneath him. Grimacing at the pain in his backside, he continued:

“We should follow the Pavilion Master’s orders. That’s the right call. Besides, do you think those men would dare try anything, tied up or not?”

“I suppose not.”

Hyuk Mujin nodded in agreement. Ju Hwaran and Song Ilseom then let go of the reins they’d each been holding.

Not their own reins, of course. They belonged to the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang, who had been riding close beside them, hemmed in on all sides.

“Thank you for trusting us.”

“I’m not completely trusting you yet, so there’s no need to thank me.”

That was what I told Ma Junggeol, whose eyes had filled with tears again. Privately, though, I thought otherwise.

No matter how I look at it, they’re not spies sent by Dark Heaven.

When I first overheard their Sound Transmission, the suspicions I'd set aside had come rushing back.

At first, anyway.

Now that I'd heard Ma Junggeol's whole story, those suspicions had given way to curiosity about someone else.

The mysterious master Ma Junggeol and his sworn brothers revered as Great Sir.

—What do you think?

Jeok Cheongang's low Sound Transmission reached my ear. I knew what he was asking, so I turned my gaze toward the road ahead and answered.

—I'm not sure.

—Are you holding back? Or…

—I really don't know. The man they call Great Sir seems less suspicious than… strange. Unbelievably strange.

That was no exaggeration.

This mysterious Supreme Peak master had appeared out of nowhere one day and wiped out a band of mounted bandits beyond even the authorities' control. Yet Great Sir himself remained shrouded in mystery.

They said they didn't know his name, where he came from, or anything else about him.

The Seven Masters of Baekma Bang had served him for more than ten years. Yet none of them, Ma Junggeol included, knew who he was. Whenever we pressed them, their answers were much the same.

"No, it's all true. That's just what he's like!"

"We wouldn't dare lie to you. Please believe us."

"You heard us talking, so you already know he's a bit—no, more than a bit—all over the place. His name and age? Don't even ask. They change every time. Isn't that right, Youngest?"

"My brothers are right. Chilbok, Gaettong… Was it three years ago? He thought he was a seventeen-year-old girl named Sohyang. That's when we gave up trying to make sense of it."

"We don't know when he started living in Ningxia Province, either. He just suddenly appeared, subdued the whole area with his absurd divine might, then shut himself away in his residence and wouldn't budge. He's been like that for nearly ten years. I know it's hard to believe, but it's true."

The absurd stories kept coming, like sweet potato vines that refused to end no matter how many you pulled up. Listening to them, I couldn't help wondering:

What the hell is that guy?

Everyone had their own ambitions.

Right or wrong, everyone had some goal they'd held in their heart at least once.

But Great Sir, as they described him, fit none of the possibilities.

He hadn't taken over Ningxia and ruled it as a mighty conqueror. Nor did he sound like a notorious fiend hiding his identity on the frontier, or a hermit master wandering where no one would find him as his life drew to a close.

If he wanted to rule as a conqueror, there'd be no reason to hole up in a cave. If he were a fiend, he'd have tried his damnedest to keep his identity hidden—or from the start, he'd have put the mounted bandits under his command.

As for a hermit master, I hardly needed to think about it.

What kind of deranged hermit would pass up a remote mountain valley with beautiful scenery and clear water to settle on a frontier where fine dust hung in the air and yellow sand blew through all year?

Even an ignoramus like me knew the famous poet Paul Valéry.[3638] If he'd lived in Ningxia Province instead of France, he would've written, *The yellow dust is blowing. Fuck, I want to die.*

And it wasn't as if he were some senile old man, or someone so close to death that finding a mountain valley wasn't worth the trouble.

According to the Seven Masters, Great Sir washed so rarely that grime practically ran off him. Even so, what they could make out of his face and hear in his voice suggested a man around middle age.

When Ma Junggeol and his sworn brothers brought him liquor and food, he sometimes gave them a little instruction in return. And though he mostly stayed at his residence, he went out for the occasional stroll.

He said being inside all the time felt stifling. He wanted to smell other people for a change.

He must have wandered around often enough to blend into Ningxia Province without the Seven Masters making any effort to hide who he was.

Like Beggar Number One.

This is a hermit master?

Was this what it felt like to sink into a deep mire?

The more I thought about him, the more baffled and curious I became. Then Jeok Cheongang moved his lips, apparently thinking much the same thing.

—I thought I'd lived long enough to see hundreds of cartloads of madmen… but I've never seen anyone like this.

—Your hair's only just started growing back.

—…Do you want to die?

—No. But I agree with you, Old Master. I can't make sense of him.

—Could he be one of the Lord of Heaven's minions?

[3638] Paul Valéry's poem *The Graveyard by the Sea* includes the line commonly translated as "The wind is rising! We must try to live!"

—The Lord of Heaven must have people left working for him. But if you were him, would you take someone like that on?

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation.

—Are you mad?

—Exactly.

—Even if I took a Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist to the head, I wouldn't take a man like that as a subordinate. Assuming everything those vicious-looking bastards told us is true, of course.

—But you already believe them.

—That's…

His Sound Transmission trailed off as he turned his head. The instant the Seven Masters met his gaze, they went rigid as statues. Jeok Cheongang shook his head.

—Yes, you're right. I can tell they aren't lying. No—they aren't even capable of it.

That much was plain to me, and probably to everyone else.

But even if we concluded that the Seven Masters and Great Sir posed no danger to our side, the two of us couldn't decide everything on instinct alone.

—What will you do?

Jeok Cheongang's Sound Transmission reached me again. After a moment's thought, I made my decision. I gradually eased up on the reins and drew level with the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang.

"W-why now? What is it this time…?"

Ma Junggeol and his sworn brothers were frightened before I'd said a word.

I studied them in silence, then asked, "How long would you need?"

"What do you mean…?"

"To bring the man you call Great Sir to where we're headed."

"…!"

Chapter 1013

"G-Great Sir?"

Ma Junggeol and his sworn brothers stared at me, eyes wide. It took them a moment to recover.

"No, why Great Sir all of a sudden…?"

I answered calmly.

"It's not all of a sudden. He's connected to this situation to some extent. And I'm sure you know why I'm asking, so I don't need to spell it out, do I?"

"You suspect me… no, *us* of being Dark Heaven's spies?"

"Not exactly. At least, not the people here."

"Then you suspect Great Sir?"

I shrugged. Ma Junggeol and the rest of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang went rigid.

"That's ridiculous!"

"Damn it, how many times do we have to tell you he isn't?"

"As our Chief already told you, Great Sir is absolutely not that kind of person. You heard it all for yourself, didn't you?"

Of course I had.

I'd learned only that he was a highly unusual person—the kind you rarely came across.

But this wasn't the time to think, *Huh. People like that exist,* and let it go.

"Hah! I'll stake my neck on it if I have to!"

I scratched my chin and looked at the short man who'd shouted a beat late.

"You over there. You'll stake your own neck?"

"…Huh?"

Apparently he hadn't expected me to take him up on it. He flinched and worked his lips.

"I-I mean, my neck might be a bit much. Maybe my wrist…"

"A man's word is worth a thousand pieces of gold! Of course he'll stake it! Cut off Second Brother's head!"

"Hey, you crazy bastard!"

While the shorty flailed at the bulbous-nosed man's sudden offer to wager on his behalf, I spoke in a low, measured voice.

"Wrist or neck, the math doesn't work out either way."

"What do you mean…?"

"I'm asking because I'm curious. Do you think all these people are taking a casual trip to the next town over just because they're bored?"

"…!"

The mood turned heavy in an instant. Their wavering eyes were fixed on the backs of the countless people riding far ahead.

The Black Dragon Demon Gate. The Zhongnan Sect.

Martial artists from large and small sects throughout Gansu Murim.

And finally, me and the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

That wasn't all. In the direction those thousands of men and horses were racing lay tens of thousands of our allies, who could be in danger at any moment.

Even if all seven of them staked their lives, not just the short man, those lives couldn't be weighed against what was at stake.

"Am I the only one here who's heard that war isn't a gamble?"

I'd said it almost to myself, but neither Ma Junggeol nor anyone else dared answer.

Of course they didn't.

They knew how absurd it would be to dismiss every suspicion about a mysterious Supreme Peak master on the word of a few horse-caravan men.

The Great War that would decide the fate of the world was still underway. War was no gamble.

Besides…

There's good reason to be suspicious. This isn't paranoia.

I looked Ma Junggeol straight in the eye, recalling the Sound Transmissions the Seven Masters had exchanged the day before.

"I heard something interesting in your Sound Transmissions. What do you make of that?"

"Something interesting? What…?"

"I heard you say Great Sir had told you a thing or two about which way to go. Quite recently, too."

I put particular emphasis on the last part. Ma Junggeol's eyes, already lowered with worry, visibly wavered.

"T-that…"

"Now I'm curious. Exactly how recently was it? And what did he tell you? Don't you think?"

I turned to Jeok Cheongang, who had been watching. He nodded.

"Hearing you say that, this old man is curious too. Why did you keep something so important to yourselves until now?"

Looking back, it was more than enough to make anyone suspicious.

How had the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang—former mounted bandits, unremarkable wanderers who had never distinguished themselves—come up with the audacious idea of crossing the desert of the Land of Ruin?

I'd only watched them up close for a short time, but I remembered every word of their Sound Transmissions. I already had a guess.

"The idea of opening a new trade route west wasn't yours to begin with. Am I wrong?"

"…!"

"…!"

If I hadn't followed Namho's advice the day before and moved back early, quite a few people might have been startled by what I'd just said.

But for a little over thirty meters[3639] around us, there was no one else. Ma Junggeol had only one choice left.

"…There's nothing more to hide."

The words slipped out after a heavy silence. They were as good as an admission.

Before his sworn brothers could hurriedly shout something, I raised a hand to silence them and calmly continued my questions.

"Why did you hide it?"

"Because Great Sir wouldn't have wanted us to tell anyone. Thanks to him, we changed our ways and have lived well ever since. We're not beasts. How could we go around talking openly about what he'd done?"

"Tell me more."

"This wasn't the first time. From more than ten years ago right up until today, Great Sir has given my younger brothers and me all kinds of advice. When we first met him, we were so overwhelmed by his divine might that we asked to become his subordinates. He refused us outright and said…"

Ma Junggeol slowly looked over his sworn brothers and their complicated expressions before continuing.

"A caterpillar ought to eat pine needles. He asked whether we wouldn't be better off gathering mounted bandits like ourselves, men who could still change their ways, and forming a group of our own. So my brothers and I took his advice."

"Baekma Bang…"

"That's right. That was how Baekma Bang began. Whenever we ran into trouble after that, Great Sir showed us the right way forward. The new trade route was no different."

"Then when you said you'd been considering a western trade route for years, was that…"

Ma Junggeol understood what I was asking and hurriedly waved his hands.

"I don't know if you'll believe me in a situation like this, but that part is absolutely true. Great Sir simply advised us to do it. Afterward, we started searching for a

[3639] A little over thirty meters is a little over 100 ft. The Korean uses ten-odd *jang*; one *jang* is approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

new route west and realized the grasslands were our only option. Of course, we hadn't dared attempt it all that time."

"And that's how you noticed the opening in the western grasslands so quickly," Jeok Cheongang muttered.

Ma Junggeol nodded.

"Yes. Of course, we had no idea things would take such an unexpected turn. Great Sir probably didn't either."

Naturally.

Even if Hong Dao, the Dharma King who could read the heavenly patterns, were still alive, how could he have predicted something years in the future in such detail?

That wouldn't be reading the heavenly patterns. That'd be prophecy. Prophecy.

And as Ma Junggeol went on, Great Sir's advice didn't sound particularly extraordinary.

He'd started by helping a few good-hearted mounted bandits, who had nowhere to go and had never farmed a day in their lives, put their skills to use and establish Baekma Bang.

A new trade route beyond the desert?

It was a bold idea, not one an ordinary person would come up with easily. But from what I'd heard of his martial prowess and his past, Great Sir was far from ordinary.

It was also the kind of wish the heads of the great groups bordering the desert or ambitious merchant-house leaders might have entertained at least once.

But what was this strange feeling I couldn't explain?

What the hell?

I shook my head to clear away my stray thoughts, then parted my lips, which had been closed for a while, toward Ma Junggeol, who was swallowing nervously.

"One last question. Whose idea was it to come find us?"

"I'm ashamed to say that was Great Sir's advice too."

"Thought so."

"We could have arrived half a day sooner. But this was too serious for us to decide on our own, so we went to see Great Sir as soon as we entered Ningxia."

"Go on."

"We told him what happened on the grasslands and in the desert. He knocked back several bowls of liquor as though he were listening to a dog bark, then said, 'You idiots should've gone to Gansu ages ago. Why are you still sitting on your asses here?'"

"…!"

"And after that, well, here we are. Damn it."

Ma Junggeol fell silent, looking half resigned. For a while, the only sounds were the horses' rough breathing and the thunder of hooves. The bulbous-nosed man glanced around and cautiously spoke up.

"Seven days and nights. I think that should be enough."

"What the hell are you talking about?" Jeok Cheongang asked with a frown.

The man panicked and pointed at me.

"Y-your Disciple asked us earlier how long it would take to bring Great Sir back. I was answering him."

The first time is hard. After that, it gets easier.

Ma Junggeol's sworn brothers, who had been moving their lips without speaking, finally chimed in.

"Third Brother's right for once. Seven days and nights will be plenty."

"Just leave it to us. We'll bring him back, even if we have to give it everything we've got."

"W-well, it'd take seven days and nights if we're going to the Qilian Mountains. It might take longer if it's the Great Snow Mountain or Dunhuang."

"It's not as if Great Sir is some vicious fiend. Rather than stay shut away in that remote backwater, he could take this chance to serve the Murim Alliance. Don't you think?"

"Hah! 'Not a bad idea,' you say? He's already done a great service by sending the seven of us to warn you about Dark Heaven. It's bound to be an excellent choice for Great Sir too, since…"

Whoosh! Smack!

"Gah!"

"You little shit! I told you to stop shouting 'Hah!' Did my words go in one ear and out the other?"

Jeok Cheongang moved like a ghost, kicked off the saddle, soared through the air, and smacked the shorty on the back of the head. Then he returned and turned to me.

"So? What will you do?"

I slowly swept my gaze across the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang and answered.

"Six days. No—five."

"What?"

"Five days. Whether this march stops at the Qilian Mountains, the Great Snow Mountain, or Dunhuang, you'll be back by then."

"…!"

"One of you stays behind, no matter what. I don't think I need to say who."

"W-wait. You mean our Chief…!"

The Seven Masters of Baekma Bang began to object all at once, having realized what my words meant. Then Ma Junggeol suddenly spoke.

“Fine.”

“Chief!”

“I can stay here. The rest of you, bring Great Sir back as quickly as you can. Go!”

Perhaps they sensed something in his firm manner. They worked their lips as though they wanted to argue, but at my quiet nod, they hurriedly turned their horses and left the formation.

Thud-thud-thud!

Ma Junggeol watched the six grassland horses disappear into the darkness, a deep look in his eyes.

And though his face was resolute, his barely moving lips held the words he couldn’t bring himself to say aloud.

“Fuck. I’m so fucking screwed…”

“…”

“…”

What the hell is with this guy?

Jeok Cheongang and I stared at him in disbelief. His eyes had grown damp.

Then Namho rode up, performing what looked like acrobatics on his bouncing saddle.

“I need to talk to you. Have you got a minute?”

I meant to report what we’d learned to the command staff right away, so I was about to shake my head.

Then Namho lowered his voice and whispered in my ear.

“It’s important. And I can only tell you now.”

Chapter 1014

Thud-thud-thud!

Thousands of men and horses raced across the vast plain. At their head, the martial artists of the Black Dragon Demon Gate served as both vanguard and guides.

Some, though, were busier stealing curious glances at someone riding far off to the side.

“I’d only heard about him, but he’s much younger than I expected. He doesn’t look much older than me.”

“They said he was around thirty, so that makes sense. Still, you can’t mistake the family resemblance. He’s the spitting image of the Sect Leader.”

“The Black Dragon Saber… What a killer sobriquet. So, is that rumor true?”

Was he barely twenty? The young man still had the down on his cheeks, and the middle-aged man frowned at his out-of-the-blue question.

“What rumor are you talking about? You know I’m just as clueless about the inner workings as you are, so you’re not asking because you think I’d know.”

At the older man’s open displeasure, the young one hurriedly waved his hands.

“It’s nothing. I just heard our Young Sect Leader is stronger than the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes of the Central Plains.”

“Who knows? I’ve never even seen the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

“Right. The Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.”

“What?”

“I didn’t mean you’d necessarily met the Young Sect Leader, Uncle.”

The middle-aged man glared at the young one as he slyly looked away, then shook his head.

“I don’t know which idiot’s been running his mouth, but don’t believe it. It’s all ridiculous bullshit.”

“Bullshit?”

“Yeah.”

“That’s strange. You told me yourself last time, Uncle. When you were dead drunk.”

“…!”

“So it’s true, then? Five years ago, the man who single-handedly wiped out One Saber Cuts the Cliff, the former chief of Danhyeol Bang, and twenty of his men…”

“That’s enough. Don’t say another word.”

The middle-aged man’s firm voice cut him off, but the young man couldn’t take his awestruck eyes off the person he’d been watching.

The Black Dragon Saber, Sama Pyo.

He was the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, to which they both belonged, and the heir who would one day succeed the Black Night King, Sima Gong, as leader of the unorthodox Murim.

The young man's martial uniform was still stiff and new, a sure sign he hadn't been with the Black Dragon Demon Gate long. He couldn't hide his amazement.

So the whole story was true.

Everyone knew of the bloodshed at Danhyeol Bang, once one of the powers of Gansu Murim.

Its chief, One Saber Cuts the Cliff, had been one of Gansu's ten greatest saber masters. He and his closest men had all been found brutally murdered on the same day.

And after that?

What was there to say?

A body without a head was bound to fall. Especially in Gansu, which the Black Dragon Demon Gate's influence had made the de facto headquarters of the unorthodox Murim.

Danhyeol Bang, once three hundred members strong, had collapsed. Five years later, it had faded from people's minds.

No. No one had bothered to remember.

Not the minor dispute between Danhyeol Bang and the Black Dragon Demon Gate shortly before the massacre.

Not that, on the day the mysterious killer came, the Captain of the Guards—who should have been protecting the pleasure house where the chief and leaders of Danhyeol Bang had gathered to drink—had left with his men.

And not how that same Captain of the Guards had become the Black Dragon Demon Gate's Outer Hall Master less than a month later.

It had all been forgotten. It had to be.

The identity of the killer skilled enough to slay one of Gansu's ten greatest saber masters, the background of whoever had ordered the killing, and even where all of Danhyeol Bang's property and farmland had gone.

But the forgetting was only on the surface. The unorthodox martial artists who knew what had happened were certain.

And they were in awe.

Just like the young man who, as an unorthodox martial artist himself, now looked at Sama Pyo with admiration.

"That's really, really incredible. Don't you think? No wonder he became the heir over his older half-brothers—"

The young man caught his breath.

Reflected in his trembling eyes was the middle-aged man, face twisted as he gripped his sword hilt.

“You really do have a death wish, don’t you?”

His voice was so low that even the young man riding beside him would have missed it if he hadn’t been listening closely.

But the killing intent in it seemed to squeeze the raw novice’s heart.

“W-why all of a sudden…?”

“Shut your mouth if you want to live even a few more days.”

The older man cut off his stammering and quickly scanned their surroundings.

Perhaps the vast plain had spared them. There was plenty of distance between the riders, and the thunder of thousands of hooves and the fierce wind swallowed their conversation before anyone else could hear it.

“You idiot.”

“U-Uncle.”

“I won’t say it twice. Keep your mouth shut if you want to live.”

“I-I understand.”

Leaving the trembling young man behind, the middle-aged man urged his horse faster. His expression stayed cold, but inwardly he sighed.

The kid probably had no idea how careless and stupid a mistake he’d just made. If those words—practically taboo within the Black Dragon Demon Gate—had passed from mouth to ear and reached the higher-ups, they would have cost him his life.

Maybe he’ll never know.

It takes time for a person to mature. But war can arrive without warning, and enemies can steal that time before it runs its course.

The middle-aged man’s gaze grew distant as he thought of the battle to come. Then he flinched.

What was that?

An inexplicable sense of déjà vu seized him for an instant. He hurriedly looked around, but couldn’t place the feeling. At last he turned his attention back to his duty.

He never realized that two pairs of eyes had swept over him from more than thirty yards away.

“Hyah!”

Prrr, prrr.

His fine horse raced on, breathing hard. The young man finally came to his senses and hurried after him, his face deathly pale.

“W-wait for me!”

One person speaking alone was just talking. Ten voices became a shout; more than a hundred, a roar.

Yet even as three thousand men and horses raced in the same direction, father and son could hear each other clearly.

“There are a lot of faces I don’t recognize.”

“That’s how things turned out.”

“And a few who look useful, too.”

“Even in mud scraped together in a hurry, you can find a pearl or two. Though they can crack over the smallest thing.”

The son knew what his father meant by that last remark and fell silent. His father noticed.

As he always did.

“Are those people bothering you?”

At the Black Night King Sima Gong’s quiet question, Sama Pyo kept his eyes on the road ahead.

“I don’t know what you mean.”

“Seeing the sights of the Central Plains seems to have made you fond of word games.”

“There wasn’t much worth seeing. Maybe I was cursed with bad luck, but everywhere I went, I found a sea of corpses and blood. Though I’m sure you already knew that.”

“Yes, I heard the reports. But the messenger pigeons stopped returning one day. Some mishap along the way, perhaps. I had to look into matters myself, and the distance made it hard to get information in time. The Inner Hall Master had quite a time of it.”

“It couldn’t be helped. Yunnan wasn’t a good place to send messages back and forth.”

“I’m not scolding you. Your father knows what happened at the Nanman Beast Palace. But…”

Sama Pyo listened in silence, hoping his father’s next words would be the ones he wanted to hear.

They weren’t.

As always.

“Why didn’t you send a missive after that?”

“A missive…?”

“Yes. I understand you had several chances after leaving Yunnan. In the Imperial Capital, and at the Jin Family of Taiyuan. Am I wrong?”

What was he supposed to say?

His mouth felt gritty, as if he'd chewed a fistful of sand. The wind battered his body as he answered.

"You're half right and half wrong."

"What?"

"In the Imperial Capital, I had to hide my identity and even disguise myself to avoid being watched. The journey there wasn't smooth, either. And once we entered the Imperial Palace, things only got worse."

Sima Gong studied his son's profile as though searching for the tiniest crack.

"Go on."

"Things didn't improve immediately after the incident at the Imperial Palace. We had to stay there a while, then head straight for Shanxi without proper rest."

"Unlike at the Imperial Palace, you suffered no injuries of note in Shanxi, as I understand it. Am I mistaken?"

"You're right. That's when I was finally able to receive the missive from our sect."

"Then you saw the order."

"Yes. I saw it. I'm certain."

At the answer, given without a hint of hesitation, Sima Gong's gaze grew darker.

"The Fire King and his Disciple were to go to Qinghai, not here. Was that what the order said?"

"It was."

"It said our sect was in danger, and that you, at least, were to return to Gansu by any means necessary. Is that right?"

"Exactly."

"Then, lastly—do you have a proper reason or justification for seeing my seal and still not carrying out the order?"

Sama Pyo turned and looked his father straight in the eye.

"No."

"…!"

"I won't make excuses. I won't give you any reason. I failed to carry out the order properly, so I'll accept whatever punishment I deserve. Please forgive me."

Sima Gong fell silent, taken aback by his son's response. Then a low laugh broke the brief silence between them.

"Ha. Hahaha."

None of the men surrounding father and son like guards reacted. They were all Peak masters, Sima Gong's loyal hands and feet, but in their lord's presence they might as well have been blind and deaf.

Sama Pyo was different.

He watched his father calmly until the laughter stopped and a voice took its place.

"Pyo. My son."

The voice was soft as silk. His eyes were sharp as blades.

“If you dared to lie to my face—if you did…”

His words faded unfinished, and his eyes curved into crescents.

“Only today do I realize how right I was to send you to the Central Plains.”

Pat. Pat.

Perhaps it was the wind sweeping across the plain that made his touch feel so cold. Sima Gong patted his son’s shoulder, looking pleased.

“You’ve grown. Admirably so.”

He turned his horse and rode away. Sama Pyo watched him go in silence.

“Take care of those two from a moment ago.”

With a single sentence, Sima Gong had decided the fate of two nameless martial artists for a careless remark spoken only briefly. Sama Pyo kept watching until his father disappeared from view.

Then Taishan came over—an old friend who had been as steady as the mountain he was named for since childhood—and asked in a trembling voice, “M-my lord. Are you all right?”

“Yes. I’m fine,” Sama Pyo answered calmly.

It was strange.

They were riding across an immense plain. Why, then, did his chest feel so tight?

And why did a few faces pass through his mind beneath the gray sky spread over them all?

But Sama Pyo didn’t turn his horse around.

The place he belonged now was the Black Dragon Demon Gate, not the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Chapter 1015

Our force numbered a staggering three thousand, but every last one of them was a martial artist, so we moved far faster than common sense would suggest.

Only two days after leaving Tianshui, on Gansu's eastern edge, we had already passed Lanzhou, the provincial capital, and were pressing on without slowing down.

It must have been around then that the bitterly cold plateau and vast wilderness gave way to a narrow road lined on both sides by rocky hills of every size.

This place…

Sometimes, when I left the modern world behind and roamed the Murim, I found myself stopped short by nature's grandeur. Places untouched by human hands, holding the passage of countless ages within them.

I let go of my reins and gazed in silence at the endless view below the plateau. A soft voice reached my ear.

"This is the Hexi Corridor. It's called that because it runs west of the Yellow River like a corridor. I don't know who first named it, but doesn't it suit the place?"

I agreed, but that aside, the voice was easy to recognize. It would have been even if Sama Pyo and Taishan hadn't been away.

There was only one person around me with a voice that fresh and clear.

"You certainly know your stuff, Young Lady Ju."

Ju Hwaran gave a shy smile.

"It's only natural. I did lead the Escort Bureau for a while, even if it wasn't very long. And I am the Escort King's granddaughter, after all."

She had a point, but she was being modest, too.

Being born into a martial family didn't mean you had to learn martial arts. Likewise, Ju Hwaran hadn't been obliged to take over the family business. She knew the geography of the Central Plains and so much else through her own effort.

Come to think of it, the Yongbong Escort Bureau wasn't in a situation all that different from the Jin Family of Taiyuan's at first.

Both families had left their former glory behind and begun to fall into ruin.

One small difference was that, unlike the Jin Family of Taiyuan, which had three sons and a whole lot of testosterone, Ju Hwaran was an only child—and had to bear that much heavier burden alone.

Though her father, the Head of the Escort Bureau, was still there, unlike mine, even if he was bedridden.

But that was all in the past.

The Head of the Yongbong Escort Bureau had recovered his vitality and returned to the front lines. And the huge sum of gold I'd beaten out of the Taeeul Merciless Sword in return had been more than enough to pull the crumbling family back onto its feet.

And the Jin Family of Taiyuan had risen into the ranks of the Five Great Families, filling the void left by the Murong Family—or rather, the Murong household.

If Dark Heaven didn't exist, we could've wrapped things up here with a happy ending for everyone.

But reality wasn't something you could ignore. You had to face it, and opportunity always came in the midst of crisis.

That was how Ju Hwaran and the Yongbong Escort Bureau, and I and the Jin Family of Taiyuan, had overcome their crises and grown stronger.

It was only the many sacrifices we'd made along the way—and the fact that more would inevitably come—that weighed heavily on my heart.

And besides…

No. Not right now. I'll leave it there for the moment.

I pushed away the memory of Namho coming to me just yesterday, his face unusually grave. I pushed away his low voice, too, though it still seemed to linger in my ears.

Ju Hwaran was watching me with concern. I forced a smile as if nothing were wrong.

"Ah, sorry. I was just… just thinking about something."

"It's all right. I understand. The coming battle must be weighing on you."

What was I supposed to say? I couldn't tell her something I wasn't even certain of myself.

I watched her profile as she rode beside me, then spoke almost on impulse.

"That's part of it. But I've also been thinking about relationships."

"Relationships?"

"Between people. Trust, hopes. Things like that."

I looked toward the narrow pass between the distant rocky hills, where thousands of our allies were pouring through like a flood.

"Nothing's easy, I suppose, but I find this especially hard. The connections and feelings between people."

"How they feel…"

Ju Hwaran murmured the words to herself, then added quietly, "I think I understand."

"I thought you might, Young Lady Ju."

She'd been through it herself. How could she not?

I still remembered it clearly: during the conflict with the Zhongnan Sect, Ju Hwaran had personally cut down Chief Escort Heo Jun, who had betrayed her from the shadows.

She once followed him like a real uncle. The wound from that must still be with her.

That was why relationships were so difficult.

You could readily give someone something, but no one knew whether they'd give as much in return, more—or nothing at all.

That's why I'm hesitating so much, too.

Then Ju Hwaran blurted out something that swept the doubts creeping back into my mind clean away.

"It's Wolhwa, isn't it?"

"Y-yes?"

I'd almost agreed without thinking. I blinked at her.

What? Had I heard her wrong?

"Um, sorry, what did you just say?"

Without turning her head, Ju Hwaran answered, "The woman named Wolhwa. The Lower District Sect's Branch Leader in Shaanxi. Isn't she?"

"Yes. That's right."

"Exactly."

"No, I meant that she's the Branch Leader in Shaanxi."

"Oh, really?"

"Yes."

"And?"

"Pardon?"

"Never mind."

What on earth was this conversation?

I stared at her, speechless. Then a violent fit of coughing cut through the pounding hooves.

"Cough! Cough! Couuugh!"

What was that idiot doing now?

I turned to say something to Hyuk Mujin, who was practically convulsing in his saddle, and saw him desperately shaking his head. Namho and Song Ilseom rode on either side of him, looking at me with pity.

A suspicion struck me.

Hmm.

Hmmm.

Was this… what I thought it was?

This isn't exactly the best time for something like this.

Still, I had to clear up a needless misunderstanding.

Feeling a little strange, I spoke.

“Um, Young Lady Ju?”

“Yes. Go ahead.”

She kept her eyes fixed straight ahead, as if she’d spotted her family’s sworn enemy up the road. Her ears, meanwhile, had perked up.

I scratched my chin, though it didn’t itch.

“Well, this isn’t something you’re particularly curious about, but I thought I’d mention it.”

“That’s right. I’m not particularly curious, but I’ll hear you out.”

“I’m not very close with Wolhwa.”

“…”

“We did have some dealings, sure. Just a year or two ago, she was the Branch Leader in Shanxi, not Shaanxi. The Lower District Sect and I had various mutual dealings, so we got to know each other a little.”

After a brief silence, Ju Hwaran spoke.

“You talk about her awfully casually for someone you’re not close to. You even call her by her name.”

“You’ve got the wrong idea. I only call her that because she isn’t here. Face-to-face, I’d address her properly every time.”

“I see. So you sometimes exchange heartfelt missives like this one, too?”

“Missives?”

I blinked. Only then did I begin to understand why she’d brought up Wolhwa.

The missive the Lower District Sect member who’d guided us to Gansu had given me. The one sent in Wolhwa’s name.

“Was that why?”

“Why what?”

“That’s, well…”

How was I supposed to put this? Was it even a good idea to say what I was thinking?

While I hesitated, Ju Hwaran finally turned and looked me straight in the eye.

“Can I ask what was written in that missive?”

Strange.

Our saddles jolted with every pounding hoof, and the wind whipped past us. Yet her voice reached me more clearly than anything else, though it was barely half as loud as usual.

Maybe that was why I stared at her for a moment, then answered before I knew it.

“No.”

"Ah."

Her expression dimmed slightly, and she fell silent. I went on.

"I can't tell you what's in it. I haven't read it yet."

"…!"

"With everything going on, I'd forgotten about it. Want to read it together now?"

I didn't need an answer. Her beaming smile was enough.

Inventory open. Summon.

As I slipped my hand inside my robe and spoke the command, I felt something solid between my fingers.

I pulled out the bamboo tube the Lower District Sect member had given me a few days earlier, removed the rolled-up missive, and unfolded it in front of Ju Hwaran.

Hesitation? The slightest worry?

Not a trace. Not even a pinch.

Why would I have anything like that? Wolhwa only teases me with wordplay when we meet in person. When it comes to business, she's meticulous.

I had reason to be certain. This wasn't the first time she'd sent me news.

Perhaps because of the agreement with the Jin Family of Taiyuan, I'd received a couple of missives while I was away. They'd contained useful information: the locations of Lower District Sect branches, how to make contact in an emergency, and the latest news from Shanxi or Shaanxi.

Information. Nothing more.

It was the Lower District Sect's Shaanxi Branch Leader looking after a valued client, not Wolhwa writing to me personally.

So I unfolded the missive without a moment's hesitation—and immediately realized something was wrong.

> Young Master Jin, have you been well?
>
> Maybe it's because we haven't seen each other in so long, but I miss you terribly. I missed you so much that you appeared in my dream last night!

Rustle.

I let go on instinct, and the paper rolled back up.

Ju Hwaran had brought her horse close to mine to read along. She spoke in a voice so gentle it felt out of place.

"Could you open it again?"

"…"

"I was reading it."

"…Um, Young Lady Ju?"

"Yes. Go ahead. I'm listening."

I hurriedly opened my mouth, feeling like I had to say something. But her soft reply—and the steady gaze she fixed on me—sent a chill down my spine.

It was as if my body had forgotten I'd gained the power of Unaffected by Cold and Heat long ago.

How am I supposed to explain this?

I felt as though I'd stepped into a deep swamp with no way out. While I struggled to find the words, Ju Hwaran gave a faint smile.

"Never mind. It's fine. You don't have to say anything."

"Y-yes?"

"Don't mind me. Go ahead and finish reading. It sounds like a very deep and important conversation. Well, I'll leave you to it."

"Wait, Young Lady Ju—!"

Thud-thud-thud!

Before I could finish shouting, she urged her horse forward and sped ahead.

I stared after her, then silently unfolded the missive again.

Unlike usual, it was full of trivial personal chatter. And at the very end, it had one line that put the finishing touch on the whole thing.

> Hoping for the day the Yellow River runs clear and we can meet again,[3640]
> Wolhwa

"…"

She really was trying to get me killed.

I stared at the words. Anyone who read them would think we were on very intimate terms.

Hyuk Mujin approached cautiously.

"Um, Captain."

"What."

"I can see the Qilian Mountains."

"Get lost."

"Yes, sir."

God, I want to die.

[3640] The Korean expression evokes the Yellow River running clear—a rare, auspicious event—and uses it to express the hope of meeting again.

Chapter 1016

I'd had a vague sense of it since we first met, but Wolhwa was impossible to figure out.

What on earth possessed her to send me a missive like this out of nowhere?

A Meeting When the Yellow River Runs Clear.[3641]

I didn't know much about classical idioms, but even a rough, literal translation left plenty of room for misunderstanding.

A meeting like the river running clear.

Wasn't that the sort of thing you'd say only to someone you were at least flirting with?

This is going to give the gossip mill a real boost.

Of course, I wasn't delusional enough to get the wrong idea over a single missive.

I'd known for a long time that Wolhwa's interest in me was limited to her being a member of the Lower District Sect. It had absolutely nothing to do with romantic feelings.

But…

The problem is that Young Lady Ju might misunderstand—not me.

I muttered to myself and put the crumpled missive back in my Inventory.

It bothered me a little, but there was nothing I could do about it for now. Time would sort it out eventually, and far more important problems stood in my way.

And at this very moment—

Whoosh.

A cold wind swept across the plateau, and a vast mountain range finally came into view. It was a sign that we'd taken another step toward those problems.

That's…

My eyes widened before I knew it.

Vast. Dazzling.

That was my first impression of the Qilian Mountains.

"I'd only heard about them. But seeing them for real… wow."

Hyuk Mujin murmured, sounding dazed.

But he wasn't the only one. Everyone was staring in wonder, myself included.

Sheer cliffs lined a mountain range that stretched on without end like the body of a dragon. Between them, peaks pierced the clouds, rising so high they seemed to hold up the sky.

And that wasn't all.

[3641] The Yellow River running clear is an exceptionally rare, auspicious event; here, the phrase conveys the hope of meeting again.

Perpetual snow painted the mountains white in places, lending them an air of mystery, as though we'd stepped into another world.

Yet the narrow gorges between the cliffs were long and constricted, like entrances to hell. The mountains were a natural fortress.

This is even more than I'd heard.

The Eight Spring Gorge, which had changed Shanxi's fortunes time and time again, felt like a hill behind the village compared to the Qilian Mountains before us.

But the drawback was just as obvious.

"It's too vast."

At Song Ilseom's brief remark, I nodded quietly.

He was right. The Qilian Mountains weren't merely large. They were immense.

The range stretched for thousands of *li*[3642], beginning in southwestern Gansu and reaching all the way to Qinghai. Spread a hastily assembled net across all that ground, and it would be torn apart in an instant.

Especially if the big fish we were trying to catch was Dark Heaven.

So, as soon as we entered the Qilian Mountains—which were already surrounded by the Gansu martial artists' tight defenses—the leaders gathered in one place to discuss this problem first.

Or, more precisely, Jeok Cheongang and I did.

"There are too many troops stationed in the rear for what they're meant to do. So, what I'm saying is—"

"Pull them out. All of them."

Jeok Cheongang cut in before I could finish. He picked at his ear, then added, "I had a bad feeling when I heard about it, but seeing the place confirms it. Even if we threw every last man at the Great Snow Mountain and Dunhuang into this, we couldn't seal it off completely. We'd be better off gathering them all and throwing them onto another front."

Jeok Cheongang swept his gaze over the gathering like a landlord telling a troublesome tenant to clear out. Then his eyes came to rest on one man.

"I thought you, at least, would know that much. Was I mistaken?"

The Black Night King, Sima Gong, answered with a gentle smile.

"Thank you for thinking so highly of me. But I, and the Sect Leaders and Family Heads gathered here, know the Gansu region better than anyone. The Qilian Mountains included, of course."

"Know it better than anyone…"

Jeok Cheongang repeated Sima Gong's words softly, as if turning them over, then spoke in an even voice.

"That sounds like you're telling me to shut up if I don't know enough."

[3642] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi).

“How could we dare show such disrespect to you, Senior Jeok, of all people? Please take back your words.”

“Please calm yourself, Great Hero Jeok.”

“We reached this decision only after thorough discussion.”

After Sima Gong’s smooth apology, the Sect Leaders and Family Heads of Gansu Murim, who’d been watching for a cue, clasped their hands in salute one after another.

Like lackeys following their boss.

And that was when, as I silently watched the scene before me, I noticed the only one among them holding his back straight.

Sama Pyo.

Our eyes met for a moment. He wore that same unreadable expression of his. Then Sama Pyo quietly lowered his head too, following his father’s lead.

Swish.

Perhaps it was the sudden silence that made the brush of clothing sound so loud.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord spoke.

“It is difficult for this poor Daoist to judge. Everyone here is a leader of Gansu Murim, and I would like to believe you have made the right decision. But… I also think Great Hero Jeok’s concern is entirely possible.”

“More than possible. I’d say there’s a nine-in-ten chance he’s right.”

Everyone turned to look at me. I went on without the slightest embarrassment.

“Even with thirty thousand allied troops and several thousand more, splitting them up to maintain three fronts means we won’t be worth a damn anywhere. There’s a reason people say you live if you stick together and die if you scatter.”

“Thank you for reminding us all of the most basic principle, which everyone here had somehow forgotten.”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman let out a short, derisive laugh. I shrugged at him.

“You don’t have to thank me that much. People forget things now and then when they get old. Though this one’s pretty basic.”

“…!”

“Oh, sorry. Was that too cheeky?”

I hadn’t said it to get under his skin. I meant it.

Seeing the Roaring Fury Swordsman’s face turn red, I realized I might’ve gone too far—but what could I do when the words came out on their own?

Well, we were all in the same boat now. He’d understand.

Or not.

“You—no, you…”

Maybe the cheek of a young punk talking back had made his blood boil. The Roaring Fury Swordsman glanced at Jeok Cheongang, and seemed to be starting to hyperventilate. Someone else stepped in for him.

“Stick together and live, scatter and die. True enough. But not in a situation like this.”

I guess that was what fellow disciples were for.

I looked straight at the Taeeul Merciless Sword, who’d stepped in at just the right moment.

“What do you mean by ‘a situation like this’?”

“Are you asking because you don’t know, or are you pretending not to?”

The Taeeul Merciless Sword frowned.

“You seem to have forgotten what monstrous dark arts they wield.”

Nobody here failed to understand what the Taeeul Merciless Sword meant. I certainly hadn’t.

“The Moving Formation. Right. They have that.”

I nodded, then spoke again, as calmly as if nothing were wrong.

“So?”

“What!”

“What did you say?”

The questions came from all sides at once.

But I’d expected that reaction. Otherwise, I wouldn’t have brought it up.

“On the way here, I thought of something I wanted to ask…”

I let the words trail off and slowly looked around the gathering.

“If you’re so wary of the Moving Formation, why did you station an army of over thirty thousand in the front in the first place?”

“…!”

Silence pressed down on us.

It didn’t lift until someone, who’d been watching the situation with calm eyes, suddenly spoke.

“For the greater good.”

The Black Night King, Sima Gong. Him again.

Speaking on everyone’s behalf, Sima Gong continued in a low, steady voice.

“What you said earlier was right. If we spread ourselves out carelessly, we’ll accomplish nothing. So we put our heads together and considered it carefully, and this is the conclusion we reached: divide our forces among three fronts, so they can return to the rear at any time.”

At first glance, it sounded reasonable.

It was the same argument they’d made when the leaders first gathered.

But…

That was only true, as I'd just said, *at first glance*.

"It seems like a long way to go back. If Dark Heaven appears in the rear through the Moving Formation, how are we supposed to catch up with them?"

If tens of thousands of locusts descended on a field, it wouldn't take even half a day for everything to disappear.

Dark Heaven was that swarm of locusts.

And their fangs and wings were too savage and fast for us to make up a delay of several days and catch them.

By the time our allies arrived, Gansu would already be laid waste, and Dark Heaven would be heading for the Central Plains.

Did these men really not know that? They'd been fixtures in Gansu for decades, some for more than a century.

Of course they knew.

They had to.

Sima Gong's next words turned my suspicion into certainty.

"That's right. Without a doubt."

"…!"

"…!"

At that brief reply, Jeok Cheongang and I understood what he meant, and our gazes grew intent. But not everyone understood. The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, for one, was looking at Sima Gong with a puzzled expression.

"Sect Leader Sima. What exactly do you mean by…?"

His words trailed off.

But the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord led the great Zhongnan Sect. Before Sima Gong's reply had faded, a thought occurred to him, and his face stiffened.

"Surely you don't mean to stand by and let it happen? Even if they use the Moving Formation to bypass our lines and ravage the rear?"

Sima Gong answered evenly.

"Stand by and let it happen? Nothing of the sort. We've simply chosen the option with the best chance of victory."

"Wait. Then what happens to the rear? To the common people and martial artists still there?"

"I told you. It's for the greater good."

"Sect Leader Sima!"

Crash!

The chair shattered in an instant.

But even as the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord shouted and sprang to his feet, Sima Gong's voice didn't waver in the slightest.

“If Dark Heaven crosses the desert and attacks us head-on, we’ll immediately concentrate every force there. They might use the Moving Formation to take the rear instead… but that would be the worst move they could make.”

A fish that tore through a net from the outside could come and go as it pleased. But if it passed through the net as if by teleportation, it would find itself trapped inside.

A two-front war.

That was Sima Gong’s plan.

Effective, but it would demand enormous sacrifice.

A truly unorthodox scheme.

But…

Was that all there was to it?

“Whether we defend this place or burn it to the ground is our choice. Neither the Zhongnan Sect nor the Jin Family of Taiyuan owns it.”

Sima Gong’s icy gaze silenced the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord. I watched him, my own gaze sinking deep.

Chapter 1017

Sima Gong and the leaders of Gansu Murim had made their position perfectly clear:

- Don’t go demanding this and that in someone else’s territory.

Honestly, there wasn’t much room to argue with that.

Every one of them was an old fixture who’d ruled Gansu Murim for decades at the very least, and some for more than a century. Besides, ever since the Great Faction War, interfering too much in another sect’s affairs had been taboo.

And then there was the Black Dragon Demon Gate, standing at the center of it all. What kind of place was it?

Despite its relatively short history of only a few decades, it wielded tremendous influence throughout Gansu. It was, without question, a pillar of the unorthodox faction.

At least in Gansu, it stood shoulder to shoulder with the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang. In fact, it might have built an even stronger power base by now—a true regional overlord.

With Sima Gong, the beginning and end of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, speaking so bluntly, even the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had no choice but to back down after briefly letting his anger show.

But someone else had watched it all without so much as twitching an eyebrow.

“Why are you growling? You sound like a yellow dog whose food bowl’s been taken away.”

There was only one person here who could compare the Black Night King himself to a yellow dog.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

At last, the giant who’d left his mark on the distant history of Murim parted his lips. The icy gleam in Sima Gong’s eyes settled.

“I suppose I should growl. I’ll do it as much as I must to protect my food bowl.”

“And it never crossed your mind that someone else’s life might depend on that food bowl?”

“It’s for the greater good.”

“You mean your own good. The good of the select few who follow you and the Black Dragon Demon Gate.”

Jeok Cheongang slowly looked around the room.

There were around twenty people here, not counting those from the Zhongnan Sect and the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

As he looked from one leader of Gansu Murim to the next, an unmistakable sneer curled his lips.

“Come to think of it, isn’t it strange? As I understand it, Gansu has at least fifty sects and martial families, yet not even half of them are here. Ah… were the others already sent to different fronts?”

“They’re already carrying out other assignments,” Sima Gong answered dryly.

“So they were left behind. To delay Dark Heaven for even half a day if it uses the Moving Formation to appear in the rear.”

“Everyone agreed to it.”

“And before you got that agreement, did you lay out all the facts? Or did you put a sword to their throats first?”

“With all due respect, there’s something I’d like to say while we’re at it.”

“‘With all due respect’ already puts me in a shitty mood, but I suppose that’s what you’ve got a mouth for. Go on, then. Spit it out.”

Sima Gong let out a short breath at Jeok Cheongang’s continuing barbs. Then, with a calm expression, he spoke.

“We of Gansu Murim will not accept interference from outsiders in this decision, in any form. Even if it comes from the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families. Or…”

Sima Gong’s gaze swept past the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord and me, then stopped on Jeok Cheongang.

“Even if it comes from you, Senior.”

“…!”

“…!”

The air around us lurched.

Stiffened hands and feet came standard. The slight bobbing of people’s throats was an added bonus.

Even if it was Sima Gong, who was he speaking to?

Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King himself.

A terrifying old monster said to rank among the top five in the Central Plains when it came to martial arts—and first when it came to a foul temper.

He’d answered Jeok Cheongang in a downright challenging tone. No wonder everyone reacted as if they’d been burned.

Everyone except me.

That’s far enough for today.

I’d been watching events unfold the whole time, and I made up my mind.

Then, at a moment nobody expected, I clapped my hands together hard.

Clap!

The sharp sound broke the silence, short and yet seemingly endless. Everyone turned toward me, startled as if they’d just woken from a dream. I blinked at them with perfect composure.

"Oh, sorry. A damn mosquito was buzzing around."

Of course, I was lying.

With snow that never melted lying all around us, what mosquito?

But the point was that my sudden clap had instantly broken the tension, which had been spiraling toward disaster.

And the two men at the center of it understood why I'd clapped at once.

"You've grown up some. Come a long way."

At last, Jeok Cheongang spoke in a low voice. Sima Gong, as if nothing had happened, respectfully clasped his hands in salute.

"I still have a long way to go. I hope you'll look kindly on this inadequate junior."

Jeok Cheongang looked at me and put on a frown, as though something displeased him.

"You certainly do have a long way to go. Just thinking about what lies ahead, it's one obstacle after another. Isn't it?"

"With you here alongside us, Senior, what need have we of an army?"

Sima Gong put particular emphasis on *alongside us*, then lifted his head and looked at me.

"You truly have a perceptive Disciple."

"I don't know about perceptive. He's good at reading a room."

"Remarkable martial prowess, and a mind that sees several moves ahead. He's a blessing to all Murim. My son ought to have spent more time watching and learning from you while he had the chance… What do you think of him?"

At Sima Gong's sudden question, I answered without hesitation.

"He's useful."

"What?"

"Now that I've spent some time with him, he's a pretty decent kid. A little gloomy, though."

By Murim's reckoning, Sama Pyo was much older than me.

But even though I'd just thrown the whole idea of respecting my elders to the dogs, Sima Gong only smiled in a way I couldn't quite read.

"Thank you for saying so. It makes all the effort I put into raising him worthwhile."

Over his shoulder, I saw Sama Pyo standing there without a trace of expression. It struck me that Sima Gong sounded less like a father talking about raising his son than a craftsman talking about a piece he'd made.

But the thought vanished as quickly as it had come, and I spoke again.

"So, you don't plan to change your decision?"

"Decision. A choice made by firmly settling on a course of action or attitude."

"So that's a no. Then can I assume the Kongtong Sect's position is the same?"

"The Kongtong Sect opposed it, but that changes nothing. All of Gansu Murim reached this decision after extensive discussion."

Maybe. But was this really what Gansu Murim wanted?

Or…

Was it only what the Black Dragon Demon Gate wanted?

I swallowed the words hovering on the tip of my tongue and thought for a moment.

Inventory.

I mentally felt for an item stowed somewhere in that bottomless, pitch-black subspace.

But then I shook my head.

No matter how I looked at it, the timing wasn't right yet.

Not now, at least.

"Then let's do that."

"What?"

The startled question came from neither Jeok Cheongang, who was frowning, nor Sima Gong.

It was the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord. He stared at me with wide eyes.

"You're willing to accept this as it stands? Are you serious?"

Right then, before I could answer, two other voices cut the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord off.

"Everywhere you go, people have their own rules. Our Zhongnan is no different."

"Eldest Senior Brother is right. Junior Brother, remember how you ought to conduct yourself as our sect's Sect Leader."

The Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

Those were the two who had spoken.

After hearing his Senior Brothers speak in turn, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord muttered as though groaning.

"Senior Brothers. But how can we let this happen?"

"We understand how you feel, Sect Leader. But further discord could jeopardize what we're trying to accomplish."

Sima Gong calmly but firmly cut off the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord before he could continue. Then he surveyed the room and went on.

"I hope everyone will remember this. We are allies united beneath the Murim Alliance's banner, and we must not create discord over a decision that has already been made. Much less…"

Sima Gong's deeply lowered gaze suddenly came to rest on me.

"Acting alone without seeking everyone's agreement is even less acceptable. Wouldn't you say?"

I already knew what Sima Gong meant, so I nodded.

“I’ll keep that in mind.”

“I hope sending those horse caravans away wasn’t a grievous mistake for our allies.”

“There won’t be any problem. At least, if my expectations are right.”

“His name was Ma Junggeol, wasn’t it? If you’d let that man go as well… we would’ve been disappointed in you. Very disappointed.”

At the sudden drop in his voice, Jeok Cheongang’s eyebrow twitched. I discreetly tugged at his sleeve where Sima Gong couldn’t see, then shrugged.

“I’ll remember.”

After that, the meeting wrapped up in less than another fifteen minutes.

As the leaders of Gansu Murim filed out, they kept stealing anxious glances at Jeok Cheongang. He stayed silent, wearing the expression of someone suffering from a particularly nasty case of constipation.

Only after we were out of everyone’s sight and alone together did he finally speak.

“What are you plotting?”

“What do you mean?”

“Don’t dodge the question. You had something in mind, or you wouldn’t have tried so hard to hold this old man back.”

“I didn’t try to hold you back. I just gave you a look to calm you down.”

“What?”

“Were you planning to grab him by the collar and beat the crap out of him right there? The Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, no less?”

“Why? You think this old man couldn’t do it?”

“…”

Fair point.

I was at a loss for words. After a deep sigh, I started walking again.

“There was something bothering me.”

“That would be Sima Gong. You can tell just by looking at that bastard’s face.”

“That’s not it. He’s hiding something.”

At my quiet words, Jeok Cheongang’s expression hardened.

“What do you mean… Wait. Don’t tell me—”

His voice rose toward the end. I gave a small shake of my head.

“Don’t jump to conclusions. I’m not sure yet.”

“Tell me more. Don’t leave anything out.”

“Do you remember how Elder Nam came to see me out of the blue a day ago and said he had something to discuss?”

“Of course. I suddenly had to relieve myself, so I didn’t hear him out.”

Jeok Cheongang furrowed his brow and continued.

“If it was that important, you’d have told me later. Why haven’t you said a word about it for more than a day?”

He was right.

I’d always discussed most important matters with Jeok Cheongang, and sometimes found the answer by doing so.

But…

There are exceptions.

That day, that moment, was one of them.

“It’s important. Something I can only tell you now.”

Namho had approached me out of the blue and, speaking in a hushed voice, told me something I hadn’t expected.

“Just before we left the Jin Family of Taiyuan, I noticed Sama Pyo was missing and went looking for him. Taishan was with him.”

And there, the old agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion had caught a smell that was both familiar and strange.

“There wasn’t a trace left, but I’m certain Sama Pyo was burning a missive.”

No—once Sama Pyo had tried to hide that fact, it was no ordinary missive.

It was a secret letter.

Chapter 1018

“He was burning a secret letter alone, without anyone knowing.”

The words slipped from my lips in a low murmur.

Jeok Cheongang’s gaze, fixed on me, had grown dark and still.

“Could Namho have been mistaken?”

“That…”

I fell silent instead of finishing the sentence. Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet sigh.

“Damn it. So it’s true.”

At first, I’d thought the whole thing was a simple misunderstanding. A minor incident we could clear up by calling Sama Pyo over and talking to him directly.

But…

“Elder Nam was certain by the time he told me.”

“I thought so. If he’s only just brought it up, he must have spent all this time thinking it through.”

“Yes. At first, even he wasn’t sure. He didn’t have any solid evidence to back it up, either.”

Growing old meant your senses grew dull. Namho had said he’d gone over it again and again.

Was the smell that had lingered in Sama Pyo’s room the same kind he’d encountered so many times as an agent of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion? Or were his dulled senses leading him to suspect them for no reason?

And after more than seven days and nights of worry, this old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent had reached only one conclusion.

“It was definitely the smell of oiled paper burning. I’m certain now.”

Oiled paper—paper treated with oil.

It was customary to oil the paper used for missives so it wouldn’t get wet or tear easily. Naturally, it smelled different when burned than dry paper did.

“Another reason to oil paper is that it burns easily. The less you want a letter discovered, the faster you need to destroy the evidence.”

Namho had spent a lifetime as an intelligence agent. Though he’d found no trace of anything beyond the faint smell of something burning in the room, from that moment on he never let go of his suspicions about Sama Pyo and Taishan.

“I watched them from the day we left Shanxi Province. But until just a few days ago, I still couldn’t be sure whether it really was oiled paper I’d smelled—or, if it was, who had sent it and from where.”

There was one reason above all that Namho had hesitated to trust his judgment.

“He said the smell was unusual.”

“The smell? You mean the burning paper?”

“Yes. He said it was quite different from any of the burning smells he knew.”

“Burning paper smells like burning paper. What does that—”

“I’ve heard every region has its own customs and food. Even the animals they get their oil from are different.”

At that, Jeok Cheongang suddenly furrowed his brow.

“Wait. Could it be?”

“Elder Nam said there’s an animal found only in Gansu and Qinghai. Is that right?”

“Camels…!”

Jeok Cheongang gave a muffled gasp and nodded.

“So that was the source of the unusual smell.”

“Elder Nam’s spent his whole life in the Central Plains and Nanman.[3643] It wouldn’t have been easy for him to recognize it.”

“Right. Those odd-looking beasts are hard to come across. They live only in Qinghai and western Gansu.”

Besides, in Murim these days, people usually made animal oil from cows, horses, sheep, and pigs.

But on the day we first entered Gansu Province, Namho had been taking a break with the other Fire Dragon Pavilion members when he stumbled upon an unexpected clue.

“An incredible coincidence, really. I had no appetite, so I was sitting alone, lost in thought, when I caught a whiff of a smell I’d encountered before. I asked what it was. Camel meat, they told me.”

That clue had finally given Namho the certainty he needed. He told me Sama Pyo had received a secret letter, and that it must have come from Gansu or Qinghai.

As for who had sent it, everyone who knew about the letter had a vague idea already.

Qinghai was only a possibility Namho had raised alongside Gansu. There was just one person who would have sent a secret letter all the way to Shanxi Province, thousands of *li*[3644] away.

“The Black Night King, Sima Gong…”

At my murmur, which sounded almost like I was talking to myself, Jeok Cheongang spat roughly.

“You’ve gotten bold. You really have.”

“What do you think the letter said?”

“Do you have a guess?”

“I do.”

[3643] *Nanman* is a historical Chinese term for peoples to the south, often translated as “southern barbarians.”

[3644] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi).

"Then tell me."

"At the very least, I'm pretty sure it wasn't 'Is my son eating well?'"

A vein bulged at Jeok Cheongang's temple.

"You call that an answer? Even that Taishan—or Gangsan, whatever his name is—could tell you that."

"Taishan might not."

"…Honestly, I can't argue with you on that one. Speaking of that oversized fool, how was he on the way here?"

"Elder Nam said he was acting strange. The closer we got to Gansu, the more he picked at his food, and he moped around all day."

Of course, "picked at his food" was a slight—no, a considerable—stretch. He was still stuffing his face five times a day. How was that picking at his food? He was eating until he was full.

But considering how much Taishan usually ate, five meals a day was practically intermittent fasting.

And the closer we got to Gansu, the more miserable he looked. There was no shortage of things that seemed strange.

Knowing Sama Pyo, he might've kept it from Taishan, too.

Whatever the case, only one thing mattered right now.

While they were still in Shanxi Province, a secret letter had passed between father and son. It contained something they wanted hidden, and whatever it was, it couldn't be good news for us.

I didn't want to think about it, but if the worst really did happen…

"Hmm."

I shook my head, trying to force the thought away. Jeok Cheongang had been watching me. Now he spoke without warning.

"Worried?"

"About what?"

"That you might have to cut down Sama Pyo and Taishan with your own hands."

"…!"

Step.

I stopped without realizing it.

I'd been walking almost mechanically, but now I stood stock-still, staring silently at Jeok Cheongang.

"You look like you have a lot to say."

"…"

"Since you've gone quiet, let this old man tell you an interesting story."

I didn't answer, and Jeok Cheongang didn't wait for one.

“During the Great Faction War, when the world was going up in flames, I met a man called the Junzi Saber.[3645]”

We started walking again. My voice came out troubled.

“That’s quite a title.”

“Like hell it is. At first, I didn’t care for it much. The title was so embarrassingly grand it made my fingers curl up—and nearly break. But after spending some time with him, cutting down Demonic Cult bastards, I found he was a pretty useful fellow.”

“Useful how?”

“As a person and as a martial artist.”

“That’s quite a compliment, coming from you, Old Master.”

“Others thought even more highly of him. He came from a distinguished martial family, though it had fallen on hard times. He was an exceptional fighter with a strong sense of justice. No matter how dangerous things got, he led the way and never backed down.”

He’d been the very model of a chivalrous hero. First to charge, last to retreat, willing to give his life for others.

But I already had a feeling how this story, which had come out of nowhere, would end.

“Why are you talking about him entirely in the past tense? You sound like you regret what happened.”

A bitter smile crossed Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

“You’re a sharp one.”

“Was he a traitor?”

“Yes. He was a Demonic Cult lackey. But he hadn’t been one from the beginning.”

“You mean…”

“Do you remember what I told you about the Junzi Saber’s origins?”

“Yes. He was from a distinguished martial family in Qinghai.”

“In truth, the family had been destroyed in a war with another sect. ‘Torn apart’ would be more accurate than ‘fallen on hard times.‘ The only family he knew was an old retainer who’d raised him from infancy by begging women to nurse him.”

The only family he *knew*.

Suddenly, I thought I understood why a chivalrous hero whose name and face I’d never known had gone over to the Demonic Cult.

“There was a surviving relative.”

“His eldest brother, apparently. He’d been the Lesser Family Head, yet somehow survived the destruction of their family. An extraordinary stroke of luck. With that luck, and an even greater thirst for revenge, he crossed the desert and sought

[3645] *Junzi* is a Confucian term for a morally upright gentleman.

refuge with the Demonic Cult… You're sharp enough to guess what happened next."

Why did I feel as though I could see the Korean flag waving before my eyes?[3646]

A classic movie I'd seen long ago came to mind, but only for a moment. I'd cried my eyes out watching that movie. This story would have a different ending.

And the meaning of that ending must be why Jeok Cheongang had dredged up such an unpleasant memory.

"The Junzi Saber died, didn't he?"

Jeok Cheongang answered quietly.

"Yes. I killed him myself."

"Do you regret it?"

"Regret it? What do you think you'd do in my place?"

"…!"

"If Sama Pyo and Taishan are plotting something on Sima Gong's secret orders—and those orders have something to do with Dark Heaven… what would you do?"

I fell silent.

Only a year. It wasn't long enough to form a deep bond. We'd lived in different circumstances, and we had different personalities.

So why couldn't I answer?

My lips stayed pressed together, though this was a question I should have answered without hesitation.

What would you do?

Jeok Cheongang's question echoed in my ears, colliding again and again without end.

Around the time the three thousand troops, after several days of nonstop marching, reached the Qilian Mountains and were taking a brief but sweet rest—

Elsewhere, in a pitch-black secret chamber where not a ray of light entered, three people faced one another.

"Things have gone wrong. Very wrong."

"The Fire King—that damned old monster—what's he doing here?"

The two voices came at the man in the seat of honor the moment he sat down. He answered them.

"What's done is done. The situation has changed, so I asked you both here to work out a new plan."

[3646] *Taegukgi* ("Korean flag") is the Korean title of a film about brothers caught up in the Korean War.

“Things have gone badly from the start, yet you’re brimming with confidence without offering a single excuse.”

“This time, Sect Leader Sima, you’ll have to convince us.”

“…Convince you.”

The eyes of the man in the seat of honor—the Black Night King, Sima Gong—suddenly gleamed.

He stared into the darkness at the two old Daoists facing him.

Chapter 1019

Boom, boom, boom.

Rough drumbeats echoed across the rugged ridges of the Qilian Mountains. Their brief, welcome rest was over, and people began getting to their feet and assembling.

Jeok Cheongang, the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, and I were no exception. We just had a little more time to spare because there were fewer of us.

“Whew. Even a quick nap makes a difference, doesn’t it?”

Hyuk Mujin had just woken up and was stretching as he spoke.

“Sure does,” I said.

“Huh? You say that, but you look awfully gloomy.”

“You’re imagining it.”

“Doesn’t seem like it. You look like you haven’t slept at all.”

“No. I’m just not fully awake yet.”

“Ah, you should’ve slept, even for a bit. Sleep’s the best medicine at a time like this.”

“…Are you not hearing me?”

Did this bastard have himself on mute or something?

At my incredulous stare, Hyuk Mujin shrugged.

“Oh, come on, Captain. I could tell something was wrong the moment I saw your face. You’ve got something on your mind, don’t you?”

Sharp instincts.

But no matter how he asked, my current position meant I couldn’t just come out and tell him the truth.

Think about it. How would the Fire Dragon Pavilion members react if they learned the truth about Sama Pyo right now?

The more people who know, the harder it is to keep a secret.

Hyuk Mujin had noticed something the moment he saw my face. Someone keeping an eye on us might notice too.

Worry had a way of showing, whether you meant it to or not.

So there was only one answer I could give him.

“When anything could happen at any moment, who *wouldn’t* be worried? Huh?”

“Well, that’s true. It’s just… you seem a little different from usual, Captain.”

Unable to fault my reasoning, Hyuk Mujin scratched the back of his head. Then he spoke again, more tentatively.

“But, Captain.”

“What? Something important?”

“No, not really. I just wanted to tell you I’m not worried about anything.”

“What?”

“You said it just now, didn’t you? If you have nothing to worry about in a situation like this, are you even human?”

“And?”

“I don’t know what you’ll think of this, but ever since I started following you, I haven’t really felt worried. Maybe everything we’ve been through has made me too gutsy for my own good, but…”

He kept sneaking glances at me as he spoke. Then he turned toward a distant mountain and murmured as if to himself.

“You’re always there, Captain. I know you’ll fight alongside me, every time. So no matter how dangerous things get, I’m not afraid.”

“…”

“Of course, don’t let that put any extra pressure on you. What I’m trying to say is… Well, it’s…”

Maybe things had gotten too awkward. Maybe his thoughts were tangled. Either way, he couldn’t seem to finish.

I watched him for a moment, then supplied the words in my usual, deliberately curt voice.

“Don’t get caught up in pointless worries. I’ve always trusted you. That’s basically what you’re trying to say, right?”

“That’s… right.”

“Then why are you stumbling over it? You’re old enough to say what you mean.”

Hyuk Mujin looked indignant at the sudden jab about his age.

“Then start treating me like I’m older than you before you say that. Have you got no shame?”

“Mujin.”

“What?”

“Go get in formation before I pluck every last hair from down below. Can’t you hear the drums?”

“…Honestly. The way you talk, anyone listening would think I did all the talking. You got plenty of words in yourself.”

“What was that?”

“I’m going! I’m going!”

He ran off with his lips stuck out. I couldn’t help letting out a quiet laugh.

“‘I’m going’ is a casual way to say it, you punk.”

But my mutter reached no one. The words scattered into the air, and my pale breath briefly obscured something falling from above.

Tap.

A moment later, I felt its cold touch.

I looked up. Countless snowflakes were drifting down between clouds of every size.

Boom, boom, boom.

The drums sounded again, right on cue. I started walking, repeating Hyuk Mujin's words to myself.

He trusted me, no matter what happened.

At the same time, I thought of the two people who weren't here.

Had I failed to earn your trust because I hadn't shown you enough? Or…

Had I been the only fool who thought we'd become dependable comrades and friends?

Crunch.

I planted my foot firmly on the ground, already turning white beneath the snow.

By the time the unceasing drumbeats stopped, the number of people and horses heading west over the Qilian Mountains had grown enough for anyone to notice.

Grind. Grrind.

The mountain ridges groaned beneath a force numbering in the thousands.

Sama Pyo was counting the flags visible between the bare branches. Just after they crossed yet another hill and entered the wilderness again, he spoke.

"That's unexpected."

He offered no preamble, but neither he nor the person beside him thought anything of it. Father and son were used to this.

"What is?"

His father answered without turning his head. Sama Pyo studied his profile.

"That you agreed to their demands."

"Their demands?"

"At the meeting, you even argued with them to get your way. Yet in the end, you reinforced our troops with part of the force stationed in the Qilian Mountains. Three thousand of them, no less."

Sama Pyo was right.

When the drums announcing the end of the brief rest stopped, nearly half the Black Dragon Demon Gate's martial artists stationed in the Qilian Mountains had already assembled ahead of them.

"Is that a problem?"

"I'm only surprised. It isn't like you."

"Isn't like me?"

Only then did his father turn to look him in the eye. Sama Pyo lowered his head slightly.

“It was only a small question that occurred to me.”

“Then tell me what you’re thinking.”

“I thought you would never reverse a decision once you’d made it. Especially for outsiders.”

“Why?”

“Because that’s what I’ve always seen you do.”

“Raise your head.”

Sama Pyo obediently did as his father’s dry voice commanded. His father’s eyes, black as obsidian, were already gleaming at him.

“Have you forgotten what I taught you already? Never be certain about any situation—or any person.”

“…!”

“Circumstances can change suddenly. To survive and grow stronger in this harsh world, you must keep questioning what you know and adjust your calculations to every change. This time is no different.”

A few years ago—no, even one year ago—Sama Pyo would have listened in silence.

So why did his father’s voice seem as distant as an echo today, though Sima Gong was right beside him?

Question everything. Keep calculating… You haven’t changed at all.

Sama Pyo was reminded, painfully, of what kind of man his father was and the life he’d led.

Because Sima Gong had doubted and guarded against everything, the Black Dragon Demon Gate had survived even the Great Faction War. Because his calculations had been precise to the last detail, it had prospered beyond measure.

But anyone who knew the martial world knew one more thing: blood relatives were not exempt from the suspicion and calculation that had made Sima Gong who he was.

Seven older brothers. Nine older sisters.

Sama Pyo thought of where they had all ended up—children of the same father, born to different mothers.

That’s right. Those calculations are how I became the Young Sect Leader, too.

That was the Black Night King, Sima Gong.

He would stop at nothing to survive and rule. He would put even his own children on the scales, weigh their worth, and cast the others aside without hesitation to appoint his most capable child—his seventeenth—as Young Sect Leader.

In that sense, he was a man of the unorthodox factions through and through. And the blood Sama Pyo had inherited from him ran beneath his skin.

It was like a shackle he couldn't put so much as a scratch on, no matter how he struggled. Beneath the crushing weight of the iron ball chained to it, Sama Pyo's body and mind bent.

"I'll take those words to heart as though they were worth gold and jade."

It wasn't a mere empty platitude or a ruse. The words came from deep within his heart, and his father sensed his son's feelings just as clearly.

Pyo, it seems that boy is finally coming to his senses.

Sima Gong murmured inwardly and felt his spirits lift.

After all, who was Sama Pyo? The heir he'd finally had in his old age, the son who would someday inherit everything.

His innate martial talent was at least the equal of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes, the finest young prodigies in the Central Plains. It might even surpass theirs. He had a shrewd mind as well. He was a born leader.

But something started to change in him after he joined the Fire Dragon Pavilion.

His first act of defiance.

Without an order or even permission from Sima Gong, the Sect Leader, his son had joined the Fire Dragon Pavilion on his own. By the time Sima Gong learned of it, the deed was done.

The Fire Dragon Pavilion and the Azure Dragon Pavilion were newly established strike forces under the Alliance Leader's direct command. Countless eyes were watching the actions of the two pavilions.

And in the Fire Dragon Pavilion his son had joined, there was *him*.

Jin Taekyung.

The Hidden Dragon of Shanxi, who had risen to become the Divine Dragon of the world. A young giant of Murim.

Every step he took left a deep, enormous mark. His path was strewn with the corpses and blood of countless enemies, while praise and cheers followed him from people throughout the land.

Sima Gong could only watch, hoping that his son's sudden defiance might give the Black Dragon Demon Gate another chance to soar.

But the secret correspondence he should have received never came, and Sama Pyo's attitude, when they met for the first time in a year, had seemed somehow different.

At least, until just now.

I'll still have to keep watching him… But for now, I can breathe a little easier.

And it was just as Sima Gong let out a quiet laugh to himself at the sight of his son gradually returning to his old self that it happened.

Shhhwick—BOOM!

Several hundred *jang*[3647] away, a red flame shot up above a barren hill and exploded, bathing his eyes in its brilliant light.

No—everyone's.

[3647] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 1020

It happened in an instant no one could have predicted.

Whoosh—BOOM!

Even from several hundred *jang*[3648] away, everyone—including me—could see the burst of red light blazing across the distant sky and hear the explosion that followed.

A signal flare!

No doubt about it. The scouts who'd gone ahead of the main force had fired it. And it was red—the signal for extreme danger.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

Everyone froze for a moment. Then, as the danger sank in, weapons came free of their sheaths.

"Prepare for battle!"

"Disciples of the Martial Might Sword Sect, prepare for an enemy ambush!"

"Zhongnan Sect Disciples, form the Moon-Shattering Sword Formation!"

The sudden shift in their aura seemed to make the air tremble.

All around me flashed a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords. As our allies moved in unison to the shouted orders, I kicked off from the saddle, leaving a quick word for Hyuk Mujin, who was closest to me.

"Hold your position until I get back."

"W-wait a—!"

Whoosh!

A fierce gust swallowed Hyuk Mujin's voice, and the distance of a dozen *jang*[3649] disappeared in an instant.

Buoyancy swept through my body. I stepped lightly on empty air, on the wind, soaring upward even as I raced forward.

"Th-there!"

"Archers! What are you waiting for? The enemy's here! Fire!"

"You idiots, lower your bows! He's one of ours!"

My movements were so free that a few people below, still caught up in the confusion, mistook me for an enemy.

Someone was following close behind me.

"You don't give an old man a moment's peace. What in the world is going on?"

The familiar voice came with the effortless footfalls of Stepping on Empty Air, as though Jeok Cheongang were running along the ground.

[3648] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*: about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3649] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*: about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

I answered without turning around. “Something must have happened to the scouts who went ahead.”

“Something happened? You don’t mean what this old man thinks you mean?”

“We don’t know yet. But one thing’s certain…”

I fixed my gaze on the dust cloud rising over the distant, winding sand dunes.

“Whatever’s happening, it can’t be good news.”

A quarter of an hour later, I realized once again that bad premonitions, as always, never missed.

“Cough. D-Dunhuang. Dunhuang has…!”

The unfamiliar man’s lips were parched, his face pale, and his clothes little more than rags. The scouts were covered in dust but otherwise looked unharmed. He looked as though hardship and desperation had clung to every part of him.

His voice trembled as he finished.

“It’s fallen… to them.”

“…!”

“…!”

Not one of us had any doubt who he meant by “them.”

Dark Heaven.

The Fiends beyond the vast desert had finally crossed the river of sand and set foot in human territory.

The stranger was a messenger sent from the Great Snow Mountain. The news he brought stunned the entire leadership.

“S-say that again. What, what did you just say?”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord was the Sect Leader of the prestigious Zhongnan Sect, a man who should have remained steady in any situation. Yet he stammered, and no one showed so much as a trace of amusement.

No—they couldn’t have. Everyone there felt just as he did. What had come from the messenger’s lips was almost impossible to believe.

But when he repeated his account, it didn’t change.

“I-I regret to report…”

“Start from the beginning. Explain it slowly—come on!”

The messenger squeezed his eyes shut, unable to continue. Then he bit down on his lip and, under the barrage of sharp commands, managed to speak.

“It began when Jade Gate Pass was breached.”

As far as I knew, Jade Gate Pass had long ago been a major gateway on the Silk Road connecting the Central Plains with the Western Regions.

It stood in a wide-open stretch of desert. A small earthen fortress had been built there, making it an ideal place to watch the surrounding area.

In other words, a strategic point perfectly suited to monitoring the border with a small force.

Small, of course, only compared with the total force Gansu's Murim had mobilized. At the recent leadership meeting, we'd heard that at least a hundred scouts were stationed at Jade Gate Pass.

No—at least a hundred scouts *had been* stationed there.

By now, they were probably all dead.

"Are you saying they all died? Every single one?"

"We had no way to confirm it, but that is likely. The enemy apparently went undetected until it was within three hundred *li*[3650] of Dunhuang."

"Then when exactly did Dunhuang fall into enemy hands?"

"About three days ago, I was told."

"Three days ago…!"

Low groans rose from the leadership. I spoke up.

"Wait. I heard you came from the Great Snow Mountain, not Dunhuang. Who told you this?"

"I never learned his Daoist name, but he was a Kongtong Sect Daoist who had been defending Dunhuang."

"You don't know his Daoist name?"

"N-no."

I frowned.

The Kongtong Sect was a Daoist sect, and to its members, a Daoist name was as good as their own. Just as the monks of Shaolin Temple had abandoned their worldly names and introduced themselves by their Dharma names, Daoist names were basic introductions among martial artists.

That he hadn't even done that suggested two possibilities.

First, the messenger standing before us had brought false information.

Or…

He died in such a desperate situation that he didn't even have time to give his Daoist name.

The messenger's next words supported my second guess.

"I was too flustered to mention it earlier, but the Daoist was already seriously injured when I first saw him. He died moments after reaching the Great Snow Mountain."

"Good heavens."

[3650] In this Chinese setting, a *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); three hundred *li* is about 150 km (93 mi).

Someone let out a groan.

The mood grew heavier, and not only because the unknown Daoist had died.

A messenger in Murim had to be fast enough to break through an enemy encirclement, with the martial skill to back it up. If the man Kongtong had sent died moments after arriving, what state had the forces at Dunhuang been in?

Of course, everyone there—including me—already knew what had happened to them. We'd only been trying to deny the shocking news we'd heard.

"So it was true. All of it."

The messenger answered Jeok Cheongang's cold mutter.

"It's a terrible report, hard to believe, but that's what I was told."

It hadn't exactly been a pleasant dream. Still, it was time to wake up and face the cruel reality.

The others remained silent, looking as though they still couldn't believe it. A chill ran down my spine as I forced the words out.

"At least two thousand dead, and three thousand seriously injured or missing. Is that right?"

The messenger didn't answer. He only lowered his head in exhaustion. Seeing him, everyone was finally forced to accept the reality they'd put off for as long as they could.

"H-how can this make any sense…?"

"What can we do? It's already happened."

"Ten thousand. A full ten thousand! How could a force that large be defeated so easily?"

Yes. Ten thousand. A full ten thousand.

Yet the force defending Dunhuang under the Kongtong Sect had lost half its numbers—even though they'd fought a defensive battle.

In just half a day.

And that wasn't the only bad news.

"About thirty percent of the Kongtong Sect's strength was lost. During the desperate retreat, two Perfected Ones[3651] serving as Kongtong Elders and all one hundred members of the Demon-Subduing Squad died at Dunhuang."

"…!"

"…!"

Gasps sounded all around us.

This was the Kongtong Sect. One of the Nine Sects and One Gang. One of the fifteen great pillars supporting the martial world.

[3651] *Perfected One* translates *zhenren*, a Daoist honorific associated with spiritual attainment.

And Kongtong had been broken. Its forces had retreated, leaving behind two Elders said to have reached Supreme Peak more than a decade ago and the Demon-Subduing Squad, whose fame had spread even to the Central Plains.

“Then… the Sect Leader? What happened to the Sect Leader?”

At the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord’s urgent question, everyone held their breath and waited for the messenger’s answer.

By modern standards, thirty percent casualties would be catastrophic enough to call a force annihilated. Murim judged things differently.

What mattered was whether its masters survived. No matter how devastating the losses, if the head of the force was still alive, there was hope.

The Kongtong Sect Leader was Gansu’s strongest martial artist, said to be half a step ahead of even the Black Night King, Sima Gong. If he’d survived, they could still counterattack.

Dozens of pairs of eyes fixed on the messenger. He swallowed hard before giving an answer that was, at least, one mercy amid the disaster.

“I heard the Sect Leader withdrew safely from the battlefield because the two Elders and the entire Demon-Subduing Squad were prepared to fight to the death.”

“Ah…”

“Thank goodness. Heaven was watching over him.”

Sighs of relief escaped all around them. At that moment, someone suddenly spoke.

“And?”

“Pardon?”

“I asked what happened next.”

Most of the leadership had risen and fallen with every word of the report. This voice remained calm.

Sima Gong stared at the messenger with a deeply sunken gaze and spoke again.

“If the Sect Leader withdrew with the surviving troops, he must have headed for the Great Snow Mountain. Yet from what you’ve said, there’s been no word of him since. Why is that?”

Silence fell again. The messenger looked helpless.

“I—I have no way of knowing.”

“No way of knowing?”

“Yes. The tide of battle turned in an instant, so the surviving allies split into two groups and retreated. The Sect Leader led many of them away and ordered a Disciple of the sect to deliver this news.”

The dead could tell us nothing.

The Disciple, sent by the Sect Leader to the Great Snow Mountain, had pushed himself to the limit and died before he could provide any more information. The

ten thousand troops defending Dunhuang had been scattered to the four winds, and no word had come from them since.

"However, I left the Great Snow Mountain half a day ago, so it's possible that the troops from Dunhuang have joined up by now."

A few members of the leadership nodded hopefully. But I wasn't so sure.

If the messenger, who must have escaped the battlefield ahead of everyone else, was injured that badly…

Dark Heaven's great army would already be sweeping the area around Dunhuang like a net as it advanced toward the Great Snow Mountain—hunting down the survivors and moving to break the second defensive line in its path.

They're moving absurdly fast. Faster than I ever imagined.

At that moment, I realized we had no choice left.

"We're not too late yet. Send a messenger at once and mobilize every force in the Qilian Mountains."

"What?"

Sima Gong frowned at my abrupt words.

"What did you just say?"

"I said to mobilize every force stationed in the Qilian Mountains. If the Great Snow Mountain falls, it's over."

"We've already discussed that and reached a conclusion."

I shrugged at his dark gaze.

"Then change the conclusion."

"…You."

"Ah, just so there's no misunderstanding."

The next moment, I pulled something from inside my clothes and added in a low voice,

"This isn't a suggestion. It's an order."

Marquis of Shangshan, Jin Taekyung.

Sima Gong's eyes widened as he stared at the identity tablet, its characters engraved in elegant script.

Chapter 1021

The truth was, until a little while ago, I hadn't planned to go this far.

The rule that officials and martial artists didn't interfere with each other hadn't come from nowhere. In a world where the two sides barely spared each other a glance, flaunting either side's authority would only breed resentment.

But authority could be remarkably effective when used at the right moment.

Like now.

"Marquis of Shangshan…"

A low groan slipped from someone's lips, breaking the brief silence.

In the heavy, sunken atmosphere, Sima Gong stared wide-eyed at the identity tablet in my hand. It was then that he spoke.

"So it isn't a request. It's an order."

His voice was dry as sand. His gaze, gone cold, shifted to my face.

"How interesting. Truly interesting."

The corners of his mouth were stiff despite his words. I scratched the back of my head.

"I'm glad you find it interesting, but I'd rather hear your answer than your opinion. As you know, every fifteen minutes feels like three autumns right now."

"Am I to understand that you meant every word you said a moment ago?"

"Oh? You still didn't understand? Strange. I thought I'd made myself clear."

"…!"

"Well, if you insist, I'll say it again. Scrape together every last soldier you've got holed up in the Qilian Mountains and bring them to the Great Snow Mountain. Right now. That's an order from the Marquis of Shangshan."

Stifled gasps rose among the leaders.

Who was Sima Gong, the Black Night King?

He shared control of Gansu with the Kongtong Sect—or rather, he now held a far stronger position than they did.

It was still speculation, but if this crisis passed and peace returned, the badly battered Kongtong Sect wouldn't be able to stand against the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

But…

So what?

I calmly surveyed Sima Gong and the other leaders, one by one.

At that moment, they didn't look like heads of factions bearing the weight of immense responsibility and tens of thousands of lives. They looked like gambling addicts.

Fools fiddling with the tiles in their hands while tens of thousands of lives were wagered on the table.

This was when you used authority.

Even if it brought fierce opposition and discord.

Right then, one of the leaders spoke.

“From what I’ve heard, your words and conduct have been getting more and more out of line.”

I looked over. His face was fairly familiar.

He was the Sect Leader of a mid-sized sect with around two hundred disciples, a man with some influence in Gansu. He’d always stood near Sima Gong whenever the leaders gathered, so I recognized him more readily than the others.

A close associate, you might say.

“I’ll say this much: I agree with Sect Leader Seok.”

“Young Hero Jin—no, Great Hero Jin—we respect the sense of justice you’ve shown us, but surely there are bounds you ought to observe.”

“Although the Great Nation’s imperial court is now standing with us against the great enemy Dark Heaven, that doesn’t mean you should invoke your title as a marquis to strong-arm us like this over Murim’s affairs.”

Birds of a feather flock together; crabs side with crabs. Maybe it was the support of the neighbors, each adding their own word while watching the room. Or maybe it was because Jeok Cheongang stood there with his arms crossed, quietly watching without saying a thing.

Whatever the reason, Sect Leader Seok sounded bolder when he spoke again. Like a loyal dog checking his master’s mood, he stole a glance at the silent Sima Gong.

“You see? Everyone feels the same way. And Sect Leader Sima here gave the matter careful thought before—”

I was almost curious what nonsense he’d come out with next. But patience had never been my strong suit.

“So?”

I cut him off, then added quietly, “Is there a problem?”

The Sect Leader stared at me in silence, as though he’d been struck dumb. Then, his face stiff, he replied,

“And if there is?”

“Put up with it.”

“What… did you just say?”

“Put up with it, even if it feels dirty and unfair. What are you going to do about it, even if it pisses you off? Does a marquis appointed by the Son of Heaven—no, by His August Majesty the Emperor himself—look like jack shit to you?”

“T-that’s not what I meant!”

His face went red as he shouted. I couldn't help laughing.

"Or we can set our titles aside and fight it out. I won't tell His Majesty. We've only just joined hands with the Murim Alliance, and it'd be bad for both sides if something happened now. Right? Don't you think?"

My words were directed at the Sect Leader in front of me. My gaze wasn't.

Sima Gong met my eyes, and he wasn't stupid enough to miss the point.

"Those are memorable words."

The moment he spoke, the room fell deathly silent.

At last, Sima Gong spoke, looking at me with an expression I couldn't read.

"You're right. I, too, am a subject of the Great Nation. I should obey an order from a marquis appointed by His Majesty."

"…!"

"…!"

Eyes shifted uneasily around the room. They probably hadn't expected Sima Gong to concede so readily.

I'd more or less expected it.

"May I take that to mean you'll do as I ask?"

"You may. This time, I'll yield."

"So there won't be a second time."

"What can I do? I have my pride, which I must uphold even if it kills me, and my own judgment. I trust you and the Senior over there will understand that much."

Sima Gong was even wearing a faint smile now. My gaze darkened.

What the hell is this guy?

He was definitely hiding something, but I couldn't tell what it was. No—he wasn't giving me the slightest opening to catch a glimpse.

I came on strong on purpose, and he barely reacted.

I hadn't invoked the authority of a marquis and tried to force him into line simply because the situation was urgent.

Even a boulder weighing ten thousand *geun*[3652] would shake when struck. I'd hoped his reaction would tell me what he was thinking—and how many of the leaders here were with him.

I'd learned a little about the latter. With Sima Gong, I'd failed spectacularly.

And until I knew what he was hiding, Sima Gong and I were allies under the same banner.

"As you said, every fifteen minutes feels like three autumns right now. Is there anything else you need to say?"

[3652] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

I was silent for a moment. His gaze met mine across the space between us, but I could read nothing in it.

“No.”

“Good. Then I’ll send someone at once to bring in every force in the Qilian Mountains. Does Zhongnan agree?”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had been looking back and forth between us in confusion. He spoke at last.

“If the Great Snow Mountain falls, Gansu will be hanging by a thread. I see no reason to disagree.”

“Then it’s settled. Family Heads, Sect Leaders—inform your martial artists and see that they’re fully prepared. We must reach the Great Snow Mountain ahead of the enemy, within half a day at the latest.”

The leaders of Gansu’s Murim exchanged wary glances, then performed the clasped-fist salute. Sima Gong was hurrying back to his saddle when he suddenly stopped.

As though he’d forgotten something, he let out a quiet “Ah” and turned toward me.

“Could I ask one favor?”

“What favor?”

“I’d like to entrust my son to you again. The one I borrowed for a while. What do you say?”

My eyes widened. Sima Gong gave a hearty laugh and continued.

“I was glad to see a blood relative I hadn’t seen in a long time, so I kept him by my side for a few days. But in wartime, we must strictly separate public duty from private affairs. He’s a member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion before he’s the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate. Isn’t that right?”

Sama Pyo hesitated, then answered flatly.

“…That’s right.”

What was Sima Gong up to?

Truthfully, I already had a good idea of Sima Gong’s intentions. But I couldn’t let that show—not in a situation like this.

I nodded, keeping my expression and tone as calm as I could.

“Of course. I’ve been waiting for him to come back.”

“Glad to hear it. I’ll take that as a yes and send him to the rear shortly. With no telling what might happen next, a father and son ought to have a chance to say goodbye.”

At Sima Gong’s faint smile, I found myself newly certain of the suspicion I didn’t want to believe.

Before he was a member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion, Sama Pyo was Sima Gong’s son and the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

From now on, he'd be with us not as a comrade, but as a spy.

Damn it.

I gave a deep clasped-fist salute and turned away to hide the look on my face.

Thud, thud, thud, thud!

The five thousand men and horses surged forward at full speed the moment they set out.

The ground shook as though an earthquake had struck. A cloud of dust rose amid the thunder of hooves, thick enough to hide them from any prying eyes.

"Do you know why I want you to stay by Jin Taekyung's side?"

Sima Gong studied his son's face as he asked. Sama Pyo's voice didn't waver.

"What do you want me to do?"

"What you suspect. Watch their every move."

"A difficult task."

"Why do you say that?"

"Because I mustn't draw needless suspicion."

Sama Pyo had already accepted the order. Sima Gong smiled inwardly, satisfied.

No questions. No doubts.

That was exactly the way he wanted his son to be—and the way he'd wanted him to be again.

"Aren't you curious why I'm giving you this order?"

"I'll simply obey. It must be for the good of our sect."

At his son's unhesitating answer, a faint smile touched Sima Gong's lips.

"Yes. It's all for the resurgence of our family and the Black Dragon Demon Gate. Before long, it will all be yours. You'll be the undisputed ruler of Gansu then, and you may even expand into the Central Plains."

"You mean…"

His son let the words trail off. Sima Gong gave a small nod.

"There can't be two tigers on one mountain."

"…!"

"Things didn't go as we first expected, but that changes nothing. Whatever stands in our way, we'll get what we want."

As always.

The words he added quietly were swallowed by the wind. His son watched his father's eyes gleam with ambition, then turned his horse with a respectful clasped-fist salute.

There was no tender father-son farewell of the kind Sima Gong had spoken of to Jin Taekyung.

As always.

Chapter 1022

The five thousand men and horses raced forward as though their lives depended on it.

To lighten their loads by even a single *geun*[3653], they threw away the food and supplies they'd brought in the barest quantities. They whipped their horses on without a thought for pacing them.

If a horse foamed at the mouth and collapsed, its rider ran on foot, pouring every last bit of internal energy into a movement technique.

It was a forced march that would exhaust even a well-trained martial artist.

Unlike the martial artists of Gansu, the Zhongnan Sect and Fire Dragon Pavilion members had managed only a couple of brief rests. To them, the final half day must have felt like ten years.

But because we'd pushed everyone to their limits, we caught sight of the snow-white mountain range as the first light of dawn reached us from behind.

The Great Snow Mountain.

True to its name, the snow-covered range shone in the dawn light, dazzlingly white and strangely out of place.

No—perhaps the strangest thing was the fickle weather.

Just two hours ago, there was nothing but desert around us.

I glanced up at the sky, now dumping great flakes of snow as if the desert had never been there, then looked back at the Great Snow Mountain.

Dozens of high peaks touched the clouds, with the range winding between them.

The immense natural barrier lay quiet, still partly shrouded in darkness. Among the five thousand men and horses slowing as they drew closer, wariness and unease hung in the air.

It was only natural.

By now, everyone had heard the news that the front line at Dunhuang, built around the Kongtong Sect, had been utterly crushed half a day ago.

Of course, given the distance and the time, it's unlikely the Great Snow Mountain has already fallen to Dark Heaven…

War was a monster too unpredictable to reduce to probabilities.

Especially when the enemy wielded strange powers that the words *dark arts* could hardly begin to describe.

Still, I never thought the Kongtong Sect would fall this easily.

To be fair, the Kongtong Sect wasn't among the strongest of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

[3653] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (about 1.32 lb).

Even so, it had three Supreme Peak masters, including its Sect Leader. By all accounts, its disciples from the main temple—the core of its strength—were accomplished martial artists too.

Yet they hadn't held out for days. They hadn't even lasted half a day. Even I, after clashing with Dark Heaven several times, had trouble gauging the enemy's strength.

The Kongtong Sect must have had enough time to prepare, and enough strength to defend itself.

Three Supreme Peak masters at the heart of the Kongtong Sect. A thousand disciples. And a force of no fewer than ten thousand rallied around them.

Thanks to Ma Junggeol's information, we knew Dark Heaven's army numbered at least thirty thousand. But there was an enormous difference between defending a fortress and attacking one.

Hearing that Dark Heaven had overcome that difference and crushed our forces so one-sidedly brought one possibility to mind.

They have at least three Supreme Peak masters. If not… then they have one extraordinary master. Someone powerful enough to dominate the battlefield through sheer martial might.

The first possibility would be a relief. The second would make for a hard fight.

Just as not every martial artist was alike, neither were the people called superhuman.

From the foot of a mountain, you couldn't tell how many trees grew on its vast slopes or how many steep gorges cut through it.

Dozens of peaks might look much the same from afar, but up close, their heights were anything but equal.

A difference like that between superhumans must have been why our force of ten thousand, including the Kongtong Sect, had suffered near-annihilation and been forced to retreat.

Our force is formidable too. Did Dark Heaven really send tens of thousands of troops into Gansu without knowing that?

Jeok Cheongang, me, the three old Daoists of the Zhongnan Sect, and Sima Gong, the Black Night King.

There were six Supreme Peak masters right here. And thousands of men and horses crossing Gansu were bound to be noticed.

In the end, I reached one conclusion.

They advanced into Gansu because they believed they could win.

Then what made them so confident despite losing four Demon Lords and a Demon Empress?

The Blood Lord, who had vanished after the Shaolin Bloodshed?

Some other force Dark Heaven had yet to reveal?

Or…

The Lord of Heaven?

Just as those two words slipped from my lips without my realizing it, a chill ran down my spine by instinct.

Whoosh!

A sharp whistle suddenly cut through the air. I turned toward it and saw flames rising one after another from deep in the Great Snow Mountain.

Boom. Boom. Boom!

Once, twice. Then three times at the end.

Fireworks burst across the sky in quick succession, and a red line appeared along the snow-blanketed mountainside.

That's…

A signal.

The forces who had taken the Great Snow Mountain were signaling with fireworks and torches.

Sighs of relief passed through the people who'd been on edge.

Hyuk Mujin and Song Ilseom, their hands resting on their sword hilts as if ready to draw at any moment, were no exception. Neither were Ju Hwaran and Namho, who had been watching ahead with tense faces.

There was one exception: Sama Pyo, who had rejoined the Fire Dragon Pavilion half a day earlier.

…That guy.

I wanted to ask him right then and there.

Why hadn't he said a word all this time?

How could he stay so composed, as if he'd known what to expect, while everyone else had been tense and wary?

But I didn't ask. I couldn't.

I watched Sama Pyo riding alongside the still-dejected Taishan, my gaze tangled with conflicting thoughts, then quietly turned away.

If Sama Pyo and Taishan are up to something on Sima Gong's secret orders, and those orders are connected to Dark Heaven… what would you do?

Hell if I know. What should I do?

With that question still unanswered in my heart, I silently tightened my grip on the reins.

Unlike the reality before me, the dawn spreading from the east was bathing the Great Snow Mountain in light.

“Guh… ack.”

The man’s lips trembled as he vomited a mouthful of dark red blood.

His Daoist robe, once as white as snow, had long since been stained with blood and dust. His unfocused eyes could barely make out what was in front of him.

Yet he didn’t let go of the sword in his hand. He couldn’t.

Not yet. It isn’t over.

His ever-reliable Senior Brother, his tiger-like Senior Martial Uncle, and the young Junior Sister he’d thought of as a niece were no longer by his side.

They were dead. Every last one of them.

Some had been beheaded. Some had been pierced through the heart. Others had been torn apart so completely that not a trace remained.

That was why he had to get up. He had to take revenge.

Crunch.

Blood welled between his teeth as he clenched them with all his strength.

His senses had gone numb. He couldn’t even smell the blood.

He swallowed his own blood as though it were the water of life.

Forcing his unsteady legs beneath him, he swung the beloved sword his Master and his sect had bestowed upon him at the enemy before him.

With more desperation than ever. With the last scrap of strength he had left.

“Ugh. Aaargh!”

He brought the sword down with a shout so fierce that the veins stood out in his neck. At that moment, a strange sensation seized him.

Shhh.

It was as if time had stopped.

The air against his skin, the wind blowing from somewhere, even the sword blade descending at the motion of his hand—

Everything slowed. Everything grew clear.

This is…

The man shuddered.

In all his thirty-some years of life, he had felt this sensation only once before.

On the day he’d finally reached the Peak realm after grueling training, just before enlightenment came to him.

No-self.

The moment of insight every martial artist longed for: a brief instant in which they forgot even their own existence and advanced toward a higher realm.

Ah. Aah.

His eyes trembled.

His focus returned. In his now-clear vision, he saw a middle-aged man trapped in the slowed flow of time.

No—a monster who had slaughtered more than a hundred members of his sect single-handedly.

But not anymore.

Only moments ago, the monster had moved too fast for his eyes to follow. Now it stood frozen, unable to move, while his sword descended toward the crown of its head.

Die.

The man was certain.

This enlightenment had made his martial might advance by leaps and bounds.

He had broken through the wall that had held him back for so long. His Demon-Subduing Sword had finally reached eight-tenths mastery, and it would cut the monster down.

Then, in the next instant—

Whoosh! Clack.

The monster shot out a hand like a streak of light and seized the blade.

Only then did the man understand.

It had all been a delusion.

Time hadn't slowed. Only he had.

Crack!

His beloved sword shattered, and the sorrowful dream broke with it. The monster's smile filled his vacant gaze.

"That was quite a sight, watching you flail around by yourself. What do you say? Shall I give you one more chance, just in case?"

The man stared blankly at the enemy before him.

Up close, the monster looked like an utterly ordinary middle-aged man—apart from the blood covering him from head to toe.

Maybe that was why, even after feeling the truth of what he was down to his bones, even knowing that he was beyond reason, the man forced his voice out.

"Why… why are you doing this?"

"What?"

The monster—no, the middle-aged man—furrowed his brow.

"Why am I doing this? What a pathetic question. You might as well ask a fisherman why he catches fish."

"…!"

"And this is all your own fault. I told you I'd spare you for now if you surrendered quietly, but you had to… Honestly, those damned Daoist bastards don't listen until they see blood."

The middle-aged man sighed deeply and gave him a pitying look.

“From the looks of it, I won’t get the answer I want from you either.”

Already on the threshold of his final rally, the man answered faintly.

“Heaven… Heaven will punish you.”

“What? Heaven’s punishment? Did you just say Heaven’s punishment?”

The middle-aged man’s eyes widened. Then he began to chuckle. In an instant, his hand blurred and pierced the man’s chest.

Crack!

His back arched as bone and flesh were crushed. Through his darkening vision, he saw a few wisps of cloud drifting across the sky as if nothing had happened.

Then a voice pierced his ears for the last time.

“Can you see it? The new Heaven.”

“…!”

Crunch. Thud!

The hand pulled free, and his body crumpled.

The middle-aged man stepped on the corpse of the Kongtong Sword Dragon, the Kongtong Sect’s foremost young prodigy, then turned toward the vast mountain range in the distance.

The Great Snow Mountain.

Soon it would be stained red with countless streams of blood. For now, it shone dazzlingly in the rising sunlight.

“Now, let’s have some fun.”

The middle-aged man smiled. Behind him, a tremendous rumble began to shake the earth.

Chapter 1023

Huff, huff.

Footsteps climbed the steep mountain slope without a word, while clouds of white breath billowed here and there.

The Great Snow Mountain was as cold as midwinter all year round, and the air was thin. It spared no one—not even those who had come to defend this land.

If anything, these conditions might be harder on our side.

“Cough. Haa…”

Was it the altitude?

Or was Namho’s body simply getting old?

He kept coughing and struggling to catch his breath. I was about to give an order when someone reached his side ahead of me.

“Steady your breathing. Relax.”

Tap.

A hand pressed his Mingmen acupoint as a calm voice spoke. Faint qi stirred around Namho.

Whoosh.

The pallor creeping across his face eased, and his complexion regained some color. With the internal energy sent through the Mingmen acupoint, Namho looked as if nothing had happened and went back to grumbling as usual.

“Damn it. Getting old’s a crime. Anyway, thanks for the help…”

His words trailed off.

Namho had just turned to thank him when his voice faltered despite himself. Standing behind him, Sama Pyo asked with an impassive face,

“What is it? Is something wrong?”

Namho’s surprise lasted only an instant. The old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent recovered quickly.

“Hm? No, nothing’s wrong. Thought I saw something move over there.”

“Over there?”

As Sama Pyo turned to look where Namho was pointing, a small shadow sprang out from behind a dry tree and darted across the snow.

“A mountain hare. No need to worry.”

“Is that so? Well, it’s not like they could’ve snuck all the way up here. Getting old just gives you more to worry about.”

Namho replied nonchalantly, then looked at me and smacked his lips.

“Getting this winded from a little climb? I must be getting old. If I were just ten years younger—no more, no less—I’d be leading the charge. Wouldn’t you say?”

The more someone knew, the easier it was for their reaction to give them away. Namho had hidden his well enough, though. I answered evenly.

"Have you gone senile? You wouldn't be leading the charge even if you were thirty years younger."

I wasn't just saying that to help us move past the moment. All around us, people were panting as they climbed the Great Snow Mountain.

Can't be helped. We chose quantity over quality.

Gansu Province was vast, but it was still only one province. We'd managed to gather a staggering thirty thousand people by taking in all manner of riffraff.

There were boys whose upper lips had only just begun to darken, and Third Rate swordsmen who'd spent their whole lives in back alleys before growing old. Everywhere I looked, I saw people who might never have had their lives threatened—let alone killed anyone.

In the vast sea of Murim, they were small fry. Prey for the other predators.

I didn't look down on them. I had neither the right nor the inclination. I'd been weak once myself. Even now, there were people who would consider me weak.

What worried me was that we had to face Dark Heaven's forces with an army whose numbers had been inflated without adding much strength.

And besides…

More than half of them are from the unorthodox faction.

Someone once said it didn't matter whether a cat was white or black, as long as it caught mice. I agreed. History had already proved the point.

The Great Faction War had been the decisive turning point that united Murim under one banner. And during the Great Cataclysm in the modern era, even the infamous Mexican drug cartels had joined the government forces to fight the monsters.

An outside enemy could turn yesterday's foe into today's ally.

But right now, what mattered was who had put bells on all those black cats—and what he truly intended.

The Black Night King, Sima Gong.

The biggest, strongest black cat to survive the Great Faction War. Another Alliance Leader, ruling the unorthodox Murim of today.

If he already had other plans, the crushing defeat at Dunhuang and the fall of the Kongtong Sect might be nothing more than steps in a course set long ago. At the end of it, a new Heaven called Dark Heaven would be waiting for us all.

I have to stop that. No matter what it takes.

I muttered the words inwardly and glanced behind me.

Sama Pyo, walking along in silence, caught my brief look and gave me a small nod.

He looked no different from usual. Yet just then, it felt as if a huge boulder were pressing down on one corner of my chest.

Rustle.

Dozens of *jang*[3654] away, the bare trees shivered all at once. A group emerged among them, hundreds of silver arrowheads glinting between the branches.

My brief alarm eased at a shout.

“Lower your bows! They’re our brothers from Gansu Murim!”

Not everyone relaxed.

“Stand by! No one lowers their guard until I give the order!”

The voice boomed. Its owner wore rough armor and had pulled his helmet low over his face. He was heavily armed.

One thought flashed through my mind.

The military.

Step, step.

Despite his heavy armor, he moved with easy grace. He covered the dozen or so *jang*[3655] between us at a measured pace. Sima Gong, who was leading our group, opened his mouth.

Or rather, he tried to.

The man passed Sima Gong as smoothly as water flowing downstream, fixed his gaze on me, and asked,

“May I ask your name, sir?”

“Have you no manners? Do you even know who this man is, to demand an answer from him?”

Naturally, I wasn’t the one who said that.

Before I could speak, Hyuk Mujin stepped forward, putting on airs as he raised the silver tablet in his hand—wait. When had he taken that?

“If I may introduce him, he is the Third Young Master of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan, the hegemon of Shanxi Province; a Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard who protects the Great Nation’s imperial family; and one personally appointed by His August Majesty the Emperor…”

“Hong Pyo, Deputy Thousand Captain of the Gansu Regional Military Commission!”

A roar swallowed Hyuk Mujin’s voice. The knees of the man, who had stood like an iron tower, bent.

Thud.

With a heavy sound, the man—Hong Pyo—knelt on one knee and gave me a crisp military salute.

[3654] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3655] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

"I pay my respects to the Marquis of Shangshan!"

"We pay our respects to the Marquis of Shangshan!"

Hundreds of voices rang across the cold snowfield. Only then did the soldiers lower their bows and weapons. They knelt with Hong Pyo and bowed low.

Hyuk Mujin began to tremble.

"Nngh. Ugh. Ahhh."

"…What's that weird noise?"

"Captain. I think I'm gonna burst."

"…"

Burst, my ass. You lunatic.

I sighed and shook my head. Then I caught Sima Gong watching us with a peculiar look, and I smacked my lips.

"Mujin."

"Yes?"

"Go ahead. Let it all out."

Hyuk Mujin's face turned stern.

"What do you mean, let it out? It's just a figure of speech."

"…"

"Don't say embarrassing things like that in front of your subordinates. You need to maintain your dignity as a marquis. Otherwise, you'll look vulgar."

I really wanted to kill him.

Hong Pyo, the man with the lengthy title of Deputy Thousand Captain of the Gansu Regional Military Commission, was built like a bear.

To put it kindly, he was steadfast. To put it less kindly, he was so inflexible he didn't know when to back down.

In a word…

An unlucky Jeong Hogun, maybe.

Thinking of Thousand Captain Jeong Hogun, whom we'd had no choice but to leave behind because we were in such a hurry, Hong Pyo reminded me of him, yet was unmistakably different.

And the biggest reason I could make such a firm judgment about Hong Pyo's character, whom I'd only met today, was probably his attitude toward Sima Gong.

"So you're the Deputy Thousand Captain everyone's been talking about. They say no one in the world is more meticulous than you when it comes to carrying out official business."

Sima Gong had already been ignored once, but he addressed Hong Pyo with a gentle smile. Hong Pyo stared at him blankly for a moment, then spoke.

“Identity tablet.”

“Pardon?”

“Present your identity tablet. I’ll verify who you are, as procedure requires.”

“…You’re asking *me* for my identity tablet?”

Hong Pyo nodded without hesitation.

“Yes.”

“Do you not know who I am?”

“I saw you once from a distance at the City Lord’s sixtieth-birthday banquet the year before last. I asked my superior, the Regional Military Commissioner, and he told me you were the Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.”

“I see. Then you know.”

“What does that have to do with anything? That was then. This is now. My duty is to guard this stretch of roughly three hundred *jang*[3656] and verify the identity of anyone passing through. Nothing more. The Marquis of Shangshan has already gone through the procedure.”

Hong Pyo frowned at Sima Gong as though he were looking at a particularly strange man.

“Don’t make me ask again. I can overlook you speaking so casually to me, since you’re clearly older. But if you keep refusing, old man, you won’t like what happens.”

“…!”

The air seemed to freeze, and not just because we were on the snow-covered Great Snow Mountain.

Who was Sima Gong?

He was the Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, a man with enormous influence over Gansu Murim. With his standing and power, he could sit at the City Lord’s table as an equal. He had strong ties to both Murim and the government.

Hong Pyo had demanded that man’s identity tablet and called him an old man.

That alone was enough to stun everyone. Then Hong Pyo went a step further.

Swish.

“I told you. I won’t ask twice.”

He drew the iron baton from his waist. Sima Gong and everyone around him fell silent.

“Ha! Hahahaha! Yes! That’s exactly right!”

Jeok Cheongang’s laughter rang out. Holding his stomach, he guffawed as he looked at Hong Pyo.

[3656] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“A man ought to carry out the duty he’s been given. Now, what was your name?”

Hong Pyo answered Jeok Cheongang’s friendly question.

“Identity tablet.”

“…Hm?”

“Have yours ready too. You’re next, old man.”

“…!”

“And your travel pass. That bright red hair of yours looks suspicious from root to tip.”

Silence threatened to suffocate us all. Hyuk Mujin trembled and whispered so quietly I could barely hear him.

“Captain. I really think I’m gonna burst.”

But before I could answer, a sound echoed like a distant call from beyond the white ridge stretching far away.

Boom. Ba-boom. Booooom!

An urgent drumbeat.

The sound of the war drums shook the snow-covered mountain range.

Chapter 1024

For martial artists who lived on the edge of death, hearing was an invaluable sense.

Sound carried a great deal of meaning.

When you were facing an enemy, the whisper of a sleeve brushing past could only mean they were launching a sneak attack. And you could read someone's state of mind from the pitch and tremor of their voice.

To a martial artist, sound was information.

And the drumbeats rolling in from far away at that very moment were no exception.

Thump. Thump-thump. Thuuump!

There was no proper rhythm, and each beat rang out at a different volume.

An image came to the middle-aged man's mind: somewhere in the snow-covered mountains, a drummer was pounding away with all his might, looking as if half his soul had already left his body. He scratched the back of his neck.

"Did we come on a little too strong with the greeting?"

Low laughter rippled through the group at his words.

By now, they weren't the only ones who knew that the hundred scouts from the Great Snow Mountain they had encountered nearby two hours earlier were dead.

"Can you blame them? The people they shared meals with came back as corpses overnight."

"Those horses came back with heads dangling all over them. Looks like everyone's scared out of their wits already, and this is only the beginning."

"Still, we mustn't let our guard down. We don't know exactly how powerful the Fire King, that old monster, is…"

Boom!

A deafening whoosh swallowed the rest of the old man's words.

Before he could finish speaking, an immense force slammed into his chest. He shot backward like a cannonball, righted himself in midair, and tried to land.

"Ugh, bleurgh!"

Blood spilled from his lips. He lost his balance and staggered.

Unable to withstand his internal injuries, he dropped to one knee. The other two elders, who had been laughing along moments ago, stared at the middle-aged man, their faces stiff.

Having felled a Supreme Peak master with a single move, the middle-aged man glanced from his hand to the fallen elder and back, looking perfectly unconcerned.

"Well, I put too much into that. Elder Three, are you all right?"

Elder Three knelt there coughing up blood. He answered between gasps.

“I’m… I’m fine.”

“I didn’t mean for it to come to that… More importantly, what do you think?”

“What… do you mean?”

The middle-aged man smiled at him.

“I’m asking how I compare to the Fire King, that old man.”

“…!”

“What, you think I don’t stand a chance? Well, you don’t know much about the Fire King either, so I suppose it’s hard to answer. You said you’d only seen him once, from a distance, a long time ago. Wasn’t that right?”

He looked over the three elders in turn, smacked his lips, and muttered, “Shouldn’t have asked. You ran off like rats, so how would you know?”

Could there be a greater insult to martial artists, who were said to be made of pride and confidence instead of flesh and blood?

Yet the three old men—the Three Elders of Tianshan—could only tremble in silence.

Were they trying to suppress the rage welling up inside them?

No.

How could they suppress something that wasn’t there?

There was no anger toward the middle-aged man in their aging bodies or hearts. What bound them like chains was fear.

He’d lashed out with a killing blow without hesitation over a single word that displeased him. His expression and tone made it seem as though he were looking at ants he could crush underfoot at any moment.

The middle-aged man before them had both the strength and the right to act that way.

“Please forgive us!”

“I-It’s because we’re lacking.”

“This foolish old man misspoke. How could the Fire King possibly be a match for the Demon Lord?”

The three fiends of Tianshan, who had once drenched the Central Plains in blood beneath the Demonic Cult’s banner, scrambled to prostrate themselves.

If they didn’t, they felt the middle-aged man—the Blood-Sword Demon Lord—might kill them on the spot.

He looked down at them with an unmistakable sneer.

Pathetic fools. Did we really try to conquer the world with men like these?

His scorn wasn’t limited to the Three Elders of Tianshan. It was directed at the man he had once followed, the man who had been everything to him.

You were bound to fail, Cult Leader. You were only human, yet you compared yourself to Heaven.

The Heavenly Demon.

Remembering the man who had inherited that title through the generations and ruled as the king and Heaven of the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord let out a hollow laugh.

Looking back now, it was laughable. He had placed his faith and loyalty in a man of that caliber.

That he had dreamed of a Demonic Path ruling the world—a feat no Heavenly Demon had achieved in a thousand years.

But things were different now.

Failure had brought him enlightenment, and he had accepted a new Heaven.

A new Heaven called the Lord of Heaven.

His true master.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord firmly believed that the enemies drawing nearer on the Great Snow Mountain would soon serve the Lord of Heaven alongside him. Even if they refused, resisted with all their might, and chose death in the end, the outcome would be the same.

In the end, they'll seek shelter in that person's shadow.

Laughing softly, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord turned to look behind him.

Crunch. Crunch.

Tens of thousands of troops were marching toward the Great Snow Mountain, crushing the frost-covered plants underfoot.

At their head were seven strange figures dressed in black as pitch, and, in stark contrast, several dozen people dressed in white.

"You seem worried, so I'll tell you one thing."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord spoke without warning, then continued slowly, addressing the Three Elders of Tianshan.

"Someone like the Fire King could never stop us."

This wasn't confidence. It was certainty.

Certainty in the strength they had kept hidden even when they crossed Jade Gate Pass and trampled Dunhuang, defended by the Zhongnan Sect, in a single sweep.

The Three Elders of Tianshan had an inkling of it too. Even they, fiends who had once dominated their age, sensed something ominous about those figures. Whoever they were, they were no ordinary people.

But…

What exactly are they?

He hasn't told us their names or titles. How can he be so certain?

There's nothing we can do. We just have to follow him.

They swallowed their questions. They didn't dare meet his eyes.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord clicked his tongue at their bowed heads, then gave his first order on the Great Snow Mountain.

“Send them a messenger.”

“A messenger?”

“We’ve already given them a greeting. We might as well show them the mercy of offering a chance to surrender. And…”

The Three Elders waited, but he left the sentence unfinished. A faint smile crossed his face.

There’s someone I’d very much like to see, too.

He didn’t mean the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang—an old enemy who had fought on a different battlefield for a different goal.

Before the fighting truly began, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord wanted to meet not the old monster from Mount Jiuhua, but his Disciple.

The Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

For some reason, the young colossus of the orthodox Murim had drawn the attention of his master—the Lord of Heaven—in a way the Demon Lord couldn’t understand.

From the moment he received the excessive order not to kill Taekyung even if they met, his thoughts had been fixed on him.

Let’s see if he’s worthy of that attention.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s eyes gleamed.

A hundred.

Not one of the Great Snow Mountain’s hundred scouts had been spared.

They had set out four hours earlier to check the enemy’s movements. Now they had returned together—as heads dangling from the saddles of their horses.

“J-Junior Sister…”

“No. No!”

Cries like screams rose all around us.

Those who had lost people close to them in the scouting party poured out their grief and rage. Even the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, who were used to gruesome sights, clenched their teeth.

“This…”

Someone’s lips trembled, unable to finish the thought.

But in a situation like this, someone had to keep a cool head. I examined the severed heads, then exchanged a look with Jeok Cheongang.

“You saw it?”

“Yes. Each was cut with a single stroke. And the wounds are all alike.”

“So that means…”

“One person did it. That sword technique is fearsome. I’ve seen few like it in all my years.”

Death left its mark. The cuts that had severed the scouts’ heads were so uniform and sharp they looked as though they’d been measured with a ruler.

If even Jeok Cheongang judged it that way, then it had to be a master at least comparable to one of the Ten Kings—or someone even stronger—who had slaughtered them all.

“And this…”

Jeok Cheongang stopped and frowned.

“Damn it, I can’t place it. I’m sure I’ve seen a wound like this somewhere before…”

He seemed to be searching his memory, but I quietly shook my head.

The enemy’s identity wasn’t what mattered right now.

What mattered was the horrifying number of enemies approaching in the distance, raising a vast cloud of dust.

I couldn’t make out their exact numbers yet, but even just counting those pouring down the hill toward us, there were a staggering twenty thousand.

They were still several hundred *jang*[3657] away. Even so, the aura and killing intent pouring from that enormous army sent the birds of the harsh Great Snow Mountain beating their wings in frantic flight.

“Damn it. It was real. What I saw was real. Those fiends made it all the way here.”

Ma Junggeol, chief of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang, had been dragged here as something of a hostage. He chewed his lip as he muttered.

In his trembling hand was a telescope—or, as they called it in Murim, a ten-*li*[3658] scope.

“Madness. The Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples, just like I’d heard. We’re finished. It’s all over…”

“Shut your mouth, unless you want to be the first one finished.”

That was enough to silence Ma Junggeol. Hyuk Mujin snatched the scope from his hand and whispered to me.

“Captain. What do you plan to do now?”

I answered evenly.

“You know what we have to do.”

With the enemy almost upon us, only one choice remained.

Battle.

No—a bloody fight.

[3657] A *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3658] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); ten *li* is about 5 km (3.1 mi).

Once a fire took hold, it wouldn't stop until it had burned the whole field. The fire called Dark Heaven had started in the desert and reached the Great Snow Mountain. We would set a fire of our own against it.

It'll only end once everything around us is stained with blood.

Hyuk Mujin knew it. I knew it. Everyone on the Great Snow Mountain preparing to fight for their lives knew it.

And none of us knew how the battle would end.

Though someone might already have a guess.

I glanced at Sima Gong, directing the martial artists of the Black Dragon Demon Gate in the distance. Then at Sama Pyo, who stood staring down the mountainside, his face rigid instead of its usual calm.

The next moment, I realized why.

It wasn't the pressure of battle, or some secret he was hiding.

"They're coming."

At his quiet words, I turned and saw them.

A group carrying a white flag high overhead was making its way toward us through the tens of thousands of troops that had crested the hill and blackened the foot of the mountain.

Chapter 1025

There were only a dozen or so of them, yet three things made them stand out even among tens of thousands of enemies.

First, the white banner held high enough to pierce the sky.

Second, a massive black horse charging fiercely, its jet-black mane flying in stark contrast to that banner.

And third, the three old men at the front of the group.

Who are those old men?

They were too far away for even my Qi Sense to make them out. Still, I could instinctively feel that their auras were anything but ordinary.

I narrowed my eyes. By then, the group had reached the foot of the mountain, and a deep voice boomed from among them.

“You dogs of the Murim Alliance, listen!”

Backed by profound internal energy, the voice carried across the mountain range.

The old man who’d shouted had a blood-soaked shirt, though I couldn’t tell why. Jeok Cheongang looked at me and blinked.

“Goodness, how strange. I think this old man just heard a bizarre hallucination.”

“I doubt it.”

“What? Then that madman really did tell us to prostrate ourselves? And to no one else but this old man?”

“He didn’t single you out quite like that, but you do belong to the Murim Alliance at the moment.”

“I do. For now.”

“He called us dogs of the Murim Alliance, so that includes you. For now.”

“So this old man heard him correctly.”

Jeok Cheongang thought for a moment, then went on.

“Let me ask you something. When a pack of worthless mutts crawls out of nowhere and insults a Master as exalted as the heavens, how should his one and only Disciple—no, someone more or less like a Disciple—respond?”

“…”

If you’re a Disciple, you’re a Disciple. What was this “more or less like one” business?

He was still stubbornly keeping up the act. I clicked my tongue and answered with action rather than words.

Whoosh. Clack.

“H-Huh?”

Leaving the martial artist who'd suddenly been left empty-handed staring in confusion, I drew back the spear I'd borrowed from him as far as I could.

"Borrowed" wouldn't be the right word.

I wouldn't be able to give it back.

Swish.

My waist bent like a bow. My muscles contracted, my joints relaxed, and the movements flowed together as one.

At the far end of the direction the spearhead pointed, the group carrying the white banner continued shouting.

"If you throw down your weapons and surrender at once—!"

Whoosh!

The spear left my hand and tore through the air.

It outran even the fierce whistle of its own passage, becoming a streak of light. It reached its target in an instant.

Boom!

Bright red blood burst into the air.

The black horse, its body blown apart before it could even whinny, crumpled like a rotten tree trunk. The old man who'd been loudly spouting the most ridiculous nonsense dropped lightly to the ground.

A Supreme Peak master.

I'd suspected as much when he'd used enough internal energy to send his voice across the rugged mountain range. The old man was more than worthy of being called a superhuman.

Even at that distance, he'd evaded a spear carrying tremendous force and speed without much difficulty.

And he wasn't the only one in the group with that level of skill.

"That's quite a rough welcome, child."

"Launching a preemptive attack on someone carrying a white banner? Has the code of the martial world you've been going on about fallen to the ground?"

The voices were low but clear.

Through the countless bare branches, the other two old men stared straight at me.

"So it's you. That young brat we've heard about."

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, is that right?"

I put internal energy behind my answer.

"Nope."

"…"

"…"

"Kidding. It is."

"…!"

"…!"

The two old men, who'd greeted me like they knew me, looked at each other in bewilderment. So did the one whose horse I'd just taken out with a spear.

There were probably two reasons.

First, this young brat had started talking nonsense right off the bat. Maybe he'd eaten something bad.

Second, whatever that brat had been eating, he'd clearly had plenty of it. The internal energy behind his nonsense was immense.

I had no intention of explaining to those senile old men how much EXP I'd eaten by now.

I was simply curious why, after using their overwhelming forces to crush even Dunhuang, they were urging us to surrender.

First, though, I needed to know who these mutts were.

"I've told you who I am, so we might as well exchange names. There's that code of the martial world you mentioned."

The old man in the middle, his face covered in pockmarks, answered readily.

"You've got no manners for a brat still wet behind the ears. Fine. We're called the Three Elders of Tianshan."

My eyes widened.

"The Three Elders of Tianshan…!"

The second old man, fat and potbellied, nodded as if he'd expected that reaction.

"So you have heard of us."

"Good heavens. You're *the* Three Elders of Tianshan?"

At my exclamation, the third old man—clearly the lowest-ranking of the three, with a crown like a heaping bowl of rice—gave a short laugh.

"You must have heard the tales about us that have been passed down since before the Great Faction War. Are you finally ready to talk properly?"

I kept my surprised expression.

"No."

"Don't do something you'll regret. Even now, you can—what?"

"I said no. I've never even heard that title before today. And cut the 'Elder' stuff."

"What?"

"I figured if I acted surprised, you'd start blabbing on your own. Oh, have you ever heard of the Three Elders of Tianshan?"

I turned to the living Murim encyclopedia, Jeok Wiki. Before long, he answered.

"I've long heard that three stray dogs wander around Tianshan."

"Ah-ha."

“Dogs by nature, it seems. During the Great Faction War, they sided with the Demonic Cult and raised all kinds of hell in the Central Plains. This old man was itching to teach them a lesson.”

“And?”

“And what? If this old man had made up his mind, why do you think those bastards are still breathing?”

“You never met them on the battlefield.”

“Born sons of bitches, but they had good noses. They ran so damn fast I never even caught sight of their shadows.”

“Oh.”

I drew my conclusion from our brief conversation and muttered as if to myself.

With enough internal energy behind it for everyone to hear, of course.

“They were weak as shit.”

“…!”

“…!”

“…!”

The air around us trembled.

But unlike the enemy at the foot of the mountain, whose rage was boiling hot despite being invisible, the allies lined up along the ridge reacted differently.

Who were the Three Elders of Tianshan?

Fiends from a bygone era. Supreme Peak masters who’d made their mark during the Great Faction War and struck fear into everyone.

And yet Jeok Cheongang and I looked down at them and called them nothing but a bunch of dogs. Weaklings.

Those outrageous insults and absurd antics were enough to fill our allies with both astonishment and relief.

Exactly what I was going for.

With a fierce battle ahead, I’d provoked the enemy with a few words and raised our allies’ morale at the same time.

It wouldn’t overturn our disadvantage in an instant, but momentum mattered more than anything.

Of course…

If the Lord of Heaven is here, momentum won’t mean a damn thing.

The new Heaven of the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples.

Evil itself, possessed of power so immense I couldn’t begin to guess its limits.

The corner of my mouth had curled up for all to see, but the thought of that absolute being—someone I’d never once met—left a heaviness in my chest.

If someone can send the Three Elders of Tianshan as mere messengers, who the hell is leading them?

As though he'd read my mind, the pockmarked old man—apparently the eldest of the three—glared up at us, his eyes blazing, and spoke.

"There's no need for more talk. The Demon Lord wishes to see you."

"…What?"

The Demon Lord?

I frowned and exchanged glances with Jeok Cheongang and the other leaders.

As everyone here knew, all those who could be called Demon Lords were dead.

The three Demon Lords of the East, West, and North, and even the Southern Heaven Demon Empress, who had finally met her end at the Nanman Beast Palace.

But there's another Demon Lord left?

Had these bastards come up with something tacky and ridiculous, like the East-West Demon Lord or the Northwest Demon Empress?

Then someone came to mind.

Could it be the Blood Lord?

Had he filled the vacancy left by a coworker who'd been marked dead on the job?

Before the leaders could begin whispering about the enemy commander's identity, another shout rang out from the foot of the mountain.

"The Demon Lord says your safety will be guaranteed if you accept this offer!"

Dark Heaven was guaranteeing our safety?

That was obviously complete bullshit.

The leaders laughed at the ridiculous claim, and so did I.

Then, at a gesture from the Three Elders, one of the Dark Heaven martial artists following them took something from his saddle and handed it over.

Whoosh. Thud.

It flew high and landed halfway up the mountain. Our allies carried it straight to the leaders. Before I opened the large, blood-soaked bundle, I knew what was inside.

No—we all did.

Thump. Thump-thump.

"Ugh…!"

Dozens of severed heads rolled down with heavy thuds. Groans rose from all around us. Among them, Sima Gong recognized a familiar face and murmured,

"The Kongtong Sword Dragon."

I'd never seen him, but I'd heard the title.

A direct Disciple of the Kongtong Sect Leader and one of the greatest young prodigies in the Central Plains, known as one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

And the very man said to have escaped Dunhuang alive with his Master, the Sect Leader.

"T-the two Perfected Ones[3659] who served as Elders are here, too."

"The Guardian Court Chief has also met his end. How could this have happened…?"

Those already believed dead were among the heads. So were people we'd been told had survived.

The core leadership of the Kongtong Sect had come back to us as severed heads.

"Then could it be…"

I couldn't finish. Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord shook his head gravely.

"Fortunately, it seems the Sect Leader escaped their grasp. Though I don't know if we should call that fortunate."

The fighting at Dunhuang hadn't been the end.

There had been a relentless pursuit, and a horrific slaughter.

And now, for some reason, a new Demon Lord we'd never heard of wanted to see us. He'd even sent the Three Elders of Tianshan to back his demand with a threat.

"A shame you're so far away. If you were closer, I could see your faces properly."

The three old men, furious only moments ago, went on with a cackling laugh.

"You don't think this is all, do you? Hm?"

Jeok Cheongang spoke in a low voice.

"What the hell are you talking about?"

Perhaps some old fear had surfaced. The Three Elders of Tianshan flinched at Jeok Cheongang's presence, but soon answered, putting even more force into their voices.

"A thousand. We still have another thousand prisoners."

"…!"

"If you accept the offer you made earlier, we're willing to return some of them."

My mouth went dry. My stomach twisted as I asked,

"And if we refuse?"

The three sons of bitches laughed aloud.

"Want to find out?"

Damn it.

That all but decided my answer.

[3659] *Perfected One* translates *zhenren*, a Daoist honorific for someone regarded as spiritually accomplished.

Chapter 1026

Their offer was simple.

First, we would meet halfway in half an hour, unarmed.

Second, no more than three people could attend.

And third…

One of those three had to be the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

I was watching the Three Elders of Tianshan ride away, going over the terms I'd just heard, when Jeok Cheongang spoke.

"You're staying behind."

His voice was firm. He looked at me, his face set, and continued.

"Not this time."

I shrugged.

"That's not quite what I was going to say, but close enough."

"What are you talking about?"

"I was about to say something similar. I think I have to go this time."

"…!"

There was no other choice.

A thousand people.

The bastards had wagered a thousand lives without hesitation. This wasn't some empty bluff to lure us down from the Great Snow Mountain.

Even now, a long line of prisoners, looking battered and miserable, was appearing on the distant hillside, bound together.

They had to be people captured at Dunhuang, or people who'd fled only to be hunted down.

"You see them, right?"

Jeok Cheongang didn't answer. I went on.

"Not ten. Not a hundred. A thousand. We don't have a choice."

Before leaving, those three bastard dogs who'd spent their lives as outlaws had delivered a stern warning, as if they were judges handing down a sentence.

If we broke even one of their conditions, they would kill every last prisoner.

And I didn't want those people sentenced to death.

"Honestly, I'm pretty damn scared too, but what can you do? I don't know how much longer I'll live, but… if I don't want to spend the rest of it losing sleep, I have to go."

Half joke, half serious.

When will the nightmares stop?

I pushed the thought aside and made myself smile. Jeok Cheongang, who had been silent for a long while, finally sighed.

“You foolish brat.”

“Hey, what’s that for? You should be cursing those bastards, not me. Shameless pricks. They won big, then went and chased everyone down too.”

“Don’t pretend to be cheerful. It doesn’t suit you.”

“Is it that obvious?”

“You’re more shameless than anyone under heaven, yet you’ve never been any good at lying.”

“…I guess not.”

“Even if there were only ten prisoners instead of ten thousand or a thousand, you’d go. That’s the kind of person you are, as far as this old man knows.”

Would I?

I didn’t know. It was hard to be certain about something that hadn’t happened.

But… yeah. I probably would.

And I thought Jeok Cheongang was that kind of person, too.

“You’re going, right? Even if I try to stop you?”

“Were you planning to?”

“No.”

I grew serious.

“If things go wrong, we could be dead in a flash. I need you beside me, Old Master.”

Only then did Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh.

“So we die together?”

“Why put it like that? I mean we live together.”

“Isn’t that the same thing?”

“Of course not. One word can make all the difference. How could you say that? Keep it up and you’ll hurt my feelings. Can’t you feel my trust, hope, and love for you?”

“You never run out of words when you start wagging that tongue. But…”

His amusement faded, and his voice dropped.

“Do you think those men share that trust you’re talking about?”

Instead of answering, I looked where he was looking.

The men in question—the leaders—had finished their deliberations and were approaching from some distance away.

Squish. Squish.

Dozens of feet crossed ground turned to mud by snow and rain.

At their head was one man.

The Black Night King, Sima Gong.

"Have you made up your mind?"

For a moment, I stared at Sima Gong as he got straight to the point.

Then I answered.

"I made up my mind a while ago. And so did the old—my Master here."

"You understand how dangerous this could be?"

"Of course."

"Be careful. If they can draw in a major piece with just a thousand prisoners, it will be the best possible outcome for them."

He was right about that.

As much as I hated to say it, Jeok Cheongang and I had to be Dark Heaven's highest-priority targets. After all the damage we'd done, they must have wanted nothing more than to tear us apart.

But…

Just a thousand, huh.

No matter how you looked at it…

How could you talk so lightly about the immense weight of so many lives?

And how much did the outcome Dark Heaven wanted resemble the picture you were trying to paint? How sincere was that warning to be careful?

I swallowed the words circling the tip of my tongue. Then four characters suddenly came to mind, and I blurted them out.

"A large group doesn't die easily."

"A large group doesn't die easily… I see. If you and Senior Jeok go, you should be able to return safely even if it's a trap."

Sima Gong murmured the old Go proverb to himself, then nodded.

"I understand what you and Senior Jeok have decided."

We'd given them our answer. Now it was time to hear theirs.

"Then who's the third person?"

Three people could attend. Jeok Cheongang and I were settled, leaving one place open.

What happened next was more or less what I'd expected.

"I'll go. As Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, I'm willing to—"

"No. I'll go."

The two spoke almost at once.

Like a couple of middle-aged men arguing over who got to pay the bill at a bar, Sima Gong and the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord each tried to stop the other.

"We don't know what danger awaits us. Sect Leader, you should remain here."

"Then all the more reason for me to go. By that reasoning, I'm better suited to it than Sect Leader Sima."

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had a point. Choosing him for the last place was the sensible decision.

Sima Gong wasn't merely the leader of a sect. He was the beginning and end of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, the heart of the Gansu Murim world. If something happened to him, the Black Dragon Demon Gate—no, the entire Gansu force, which made up more than half our army—would be thrown into disarray.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, on the other hand, had two Senior Brothers who could take his place as head of the Zhongnan Sect. Whatever their faults as people, the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword had enough influence within the sect.

Given the danger and the importance of the positions they held, sending the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord was the lower-risk choice.

Of course…

Only if you're sure the person left behind is an ally you can trust completely.

It might be the sensible decision, but if common sense ruled the world, why would we be here?

Sometimes the world changed because of a tiny handful of madmen. For better or worse.

And one of those madmen might seize control of our rear while Jeok Cheongang, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, and I are gone.

But I couldn't argue against the decision on the strength of a suspicion I couldn't prove. Nor did we have time.

We're running out of it.

More than half of the promised half hour had already passed.

I quietly met Jeok Cheongang's eyes and knew we were thinking the same thing.

If those are the choices…

The two of us should go alone. Sima Gong was someone we couldn't fully trust whether he came with us or stayed behind. That made it all the more important for the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord to remain here.

I was about to tell everyone.

Or rather, I would have—if someone no one expected hadn't spoken first.

Step.

"Forgive me for speaking out of turn, but may I ask you both to yield the place to me?"

"…!"

I saw it clearly: as his son stepped forward, his footsteps ringing unusually loud, his father's eyes sank into a deep, dark gaze.

"Please give me the last place."

Sama Pyo repeated himself, his voice clear enough for everyone to hear.

"I'll go. Myself."

Why?

Why had it turned out this way?

I didn't know. For the moment, all that mattered was that I was walking between Jeok Cheongang and Sama Pyo.

But my patience was just a little too thin to keep the questions building inside me to myself.

"Why'd you do it?"

I kept my gaze straight ahead. After a moment, Sama Pyo answered quietly.

"I don't know what you mean."

"Why'd you suddenly volunteer? It was pretty much decided."

"If it had been decided, I wouldn't be here. Would I?"

I frowned.

"Well…"

"No one wants to walk willingly into a place that might be a death trap. Not even the Sect Leader of one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, however highly he values honor."

Sama Pyo continued evenly.

"And his disciples would do whatever they could to keep their Sect Leader from going. Wouldn't they, Pavilion Master?"

I couldn't argue. He wasn't speculating. He was describing what had happened moments ago.

When Sama Pyo stepped forward at just the right time, the Zhongnan disciples had looked relieved and done everything they could to dissuade their Sect Leader. The leaders of the Gansu Murim forces had taken their chance, too, grabbing at Sima Gong's sleeves.

If everyone left, who would be in command if something happened?

What would happen to all these people?

Sama Pyo was both the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate and a member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion. He had grounds to dissuade the leaders and the standing to volunteer himself. Perhaps that was why everyone had accepted the young man's sudden offer without much fuss.

Put in modern terms, the situation had fallen into place rather neatly.

While everyone had been trying to read each other's faces, waiting to see which leader would be left holding the bag, Sama Pyo had scratched exactly the itch they all had.

Our people already knew trying to stop us wouldn't do a damn thing.

The other Fire Dragon Pavilion members who were staying behind hadn't tried to dissuade us either. They'd simply told us to come back safely.

Anyway, everyone had gotten what they wanted.

Well, maybe not everyone.

Sima Gong.

What had gone through his mind when his son stepped forward? Had that look in his eyes been part of a plan, or had Sama Pyo caught him off guard?

And…

What the hell was Sama Pyo thinking?

He still hadn't answered my question. Instead, he brought up something that seemed to have nothing to do with it.

"By the way, I didn't know you knew Go."

"What?"

"You said it earlier, Pavilion Master. 'A large group doesn't die easily.'"

Was he changing the subject, or trying to tell me something? I couldn't tell.

"I don't know much about Go. I just picked up a few things watching and listening when I was little."

"When you were little…"

"My dad liked Go."

"I see. I've heard a little about the Strange Hero of Shanxi, your Family Head."

"I haven't seen him in a long time, but I still remember him clearly."

Sima Gong would have no idea who I meant.

In this second world, I'd found brothers who weren't related to me by blood. I'd made new companions and friends, and met a Master. But I'd only ever had one father.

Whenever he lost a game of online Go, he'd console himself by insisting those Chinese bastards must have used a cheating program. He'd also poured all his money into the stock of a certain major Korean electronics company, chanting that a large group didn't die easily.

That was Dad.

"Dad, why is the whole computer screen blue?"

"Son, what color is the sky?"

"Red."

"No, that's the sunset. The sky is usually blue. My stock's only blue for a little while too."

"Really? So it'll turn red soon?"

"Of course. This stock is a daema."

"Daema? Isn't that bad? The stuff that makes you feel good?"[3660]

"What on earth are you doing at kindergarten… No. Anyway, not that kind of daema. This means something really big and strong. And something this big and strong doesn't die easily. In Go, we say a large group doesn't die easily."

"Oh."

"Before long, that line on the screen will shoot right up. High into the sky, red like the sunset."

"Hmm. Okay. But, Dad."

"Yeah?"

"Look at Mom's face. It's really red!"

"…Honey, when did you get here?"

A quiet laugh escaped me.

I knew I shouldn't laugh at a time like this, but I couldn't hide the smile creeping onto my lips.

"It's nothing. I just… remembered something nice from a long time ago."

"A nice memory with your father."

Sama Pyo murmured as if to himself, then smiled along with me.

"I see."

His smile was dim and bitter, like the clouded sky. The sight of it gave me a strange sense of déjà vu.

Then Jeok Cheongang, who had been walking silently ahead of us, spoke.

"If you two are done laughing and chatting, it's time to greet our unwelcome guest."

At that moment, hoofbeats sounded.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

With the slow sound of approaching hooves, they finally appeared.

No—not *they*.

He did.

[3660] *Daema* means a large group of stones in Go; the same word also means cannabis in Korean.

Chapter 1027

Some people stand out.

Like an awl poking through a pocket. Like a reef rising from the middle of the sea. Like a wildflower in the wilderness.

The man approaching now, as leisurely as if he were admiring the scenery, was one of them.

Clip-clop. Clip-clop.

Gray hair swayed to the slow rhythm of his horse's hooves.

The middle-aged man's features were ordinary—neither particularly handsome nor ugly—but his pupils were long, vertical slits.

What truly set him apart, though, was the blood-red light in his eyes. Redder than flame, and far more chilling.

"This is the first time we've met face-to-face. Good to see you, Senior Jeok."

A respectful address, delivered with a smile in his voice.

That was when Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened. The middle-aged man had stopped over ten jang[3661] away, and Jeok was staring at his reptilian pupils.

"You can't be…"

"We were both too busy to meet the last time. What a shame. If you'd been there, Goyangcheon would still be alive and well by now. Don't you think?"

Goyangcheon.

I remembered the name from something Jeok Cheongang had told me.

He had been the Family Head of the Goyang Family, which once wielded power to rival the Five Great Families. Or rather, he had been its last survivor.

After the Demonic Cult wiped out his family, Goyangcheon became a man consumed by revenge. The world called him the Spear King. Near the end of the Great Faction War, that great martial artist was found in an unnamed field.

He had been cut into dozens of pieces, together with the spear he'd treated as an extension of himself all his life.

Not by a hundred men, or a thousand. By one person.

A killer who craved blood more than anyone else in the Demonic Cult.

"The Blood-Sword Demon Lord…"

The name escaped me in a low groan. The middle-aged man—the Blood-Sword Demon Lord—broke into a wide smile.

The infirmities of old age are a frightening thing.

[3661] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

Like a thief slipping in under cover of night, they steal your memories one by one.

That was why, during our stay at Mount Jiuhua, I'd deliberately pestered Jeok Cheongang with questions about his past.

I hoped it might slow his illness, even a little. Hold off the curse of time for even fifteen minutes.

As it turned out, the arrangement was pretty good for both of us.

The old man, who'd been living alone with no one to talk to, recovered forgotten memories through our countless conversations. And the young man keeping him company learned all sorts of things from a veteran of the martial world who'd lived for more than a hundred years.

One of those things concerned the killer now smiling at me.

"I'm glad. You know who I am."

The System I had couldn't read minds.

But I could feel it instinctively.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord wasn't just saying he was glad I knew him. He genuinely was.

There was a childlike innocence to his delight.

That feeling was far too pure for a murderer responsible for so much bloodshed. It made him all the more unsettling.

"I used to be a pretty big deal, you know. These friends here were fairly famous themselves, but to the Demonic Cult, they were only useful guests."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord beamed as he spoke. The Three Elders of Tianshan might have taken offense, but they only nodded, their faces stiff.

"Y-you are right a hundred times over. A thousand times."

"How could we ever presume to compare ourselves to the Demon Lord?"

"Though we are utterly lacking, being allowed to serve the Demon Lord is the honor of a lifetime."

They were remarkably good at kissing the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's ass on cue. I wanted to ask how many times a day they brushed their teeth, but from their perspective, it made sense.

The weak fall to the strong. Might Makes Right.

Those called demonic martial artists pursued strength more openly than anyone, and the Blood-Sword Demon Lord was a great fiend beyond comparison to the Three Elders of Tianshan.

Of course, by the world's standards, the Three Elders were great fiends too. Their martial prowess and the infamy they'd earned during the Great Faction War were more than enough to justify the name.

But as Jeok Cheongang had told them to their faces half an hour ago, they were stray dogs by birth.

They were simply far more ferocious than other dogs, with sharper, stronger teeth.

Still, there was no comparing them to the one mad dog who stood out even among that insane cult of fanatics, a group that had stood shoulder to shoulder with the Murim world for more than a thousand years.

Of course, its rabid dog seemed to have a new master now.

“The Demonic Cult? Shouldn’t you call it the Divine Cult?”

At my sudden question, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord smiled. He’d just called the Three Elders guests of the Demonic Cult himself.

“That was a long time ago. You know that already, so why ask?”

“So, now that you’ve changed collars, are they feeding you on time?”

“Well.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord opened his eyes wide in mock surprise and turned to Jeok Cheongang.

“Senior Jeok, how did you teach your Disciple? Even if we’re on different paths, shouldn’t we show each other some courtesy? Like I do.”

Jeok Cheongang answered calmly.

“I taught him better than your parents taught you, so don’t worry.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared at him for a moment, then roared with laughter.

“Well, well. You’re just as the rumors say.”

“And you’re worse. I regret not catching you and killing you long ago.”

“I know that fiery temper of yours, Senior. Whenever you appeared on a battlefield, useful men died left and right. The Cult Leader was furious more times than I can count.”

“That must have made things hard for you. Weren’t you the Heavenly Demon’s favorite guard dog, the one he kept closest?”

“Sorry to disappoint you, but I didn’t have much trouble. I just killed as many as were dying.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord went on, laughter still in his voice.

“When Heaven-Poison, that foolish old man, died, the Sect Leader of Hainan wasn’t enough. I had to bring back the Spear King’s head too. But what could I do? I wanted to do it.”

“Heaven-Poison? You mean the Heaven-Poison Demon Lord?”

“Well, was there another Heaven-Poison?”

I knew that title too.

Second only to the Heavenly Demon in the Demonic Cult, the Heaven-Poison Demon Lord had been a wall even Poison King Tang Taesang could not overcome. Tang Taesang, the former Grand Family Head of the Sichuan Tang Clan, was dead now too.

Then one day, the Heaven-Poison Demon Lord encountered disciples of Huashan on a battlefield. He died there.

Someone had unleashed a brilliant purple Sword Force, radiant enough to overwhelm the sunset.

“The Sword Saint—though I suppose I should call him the Alliance Leader now? In any case, I was secretly grateful to Mae Jonghak. That old Heaven-Poison always looked at me strangely. Luckily, he died before it was too late, and things worked out well.”

I watched the Blood-Sword Demon Lord chatter away, plainly delighted with himself. His last remark made me frown.

Things worked out well because he died?

Losing a master meant losing a vital part of your fighting strength. The Heaven-Poison Demon Lord’s death must have been a tremendous blow to the Demonic Cult.

And yet…

“So that’s when you changed collars.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s brow furrowed.

“‘Changed collars’ is a bit much… But think what you like.”

I already knew Dark Heaven had appeared before the Great Faction War ended.

The Head Elder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Baeksang of the Nanman Beast Palace, and even the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, who’d been the Emperor’s closest confidant…

If you traced things back far enough, Dark Heaven had been taking shape from the very beginning of the Great Faction War.

No. Perhaps…

Dark Heaven might have caused the Great Faction War in the first place.

A chill ran down my spine. I looked at the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

“When did it start?”

“When did what start? I’m not sure what you mean.”

“When you people appeared. When the Lord of Heaven appeared.”

In that instant—

Whoosh!

Wind roared around us, a violent storm of qi.

The snow and frost covering the ground, and the dirt and sand hidden beneath them, flew in every direction before swiftly settling again.

Rustle.

As the debris of nature drifted back down, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared at me with a cold, sunken gaze.

“You really have no manners.”

The smile had vanished from his lips. His voice was low.

He sounded calm at first, but cold lava flowed beneath the words.

“How strange. I can understand you to a point, and yet I simply can’t understand you at all. Why would that person go out of their way to…”

He broke off. Then his face opened into a good-natured smile.

“Well, there must be a reason for everything that person does. As always. I only wanted to confirm one thing.”

I didn’t need to ask what.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord slowly raised a hand and continued.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. You’re strong. Strong enough that even I’d rather avoid a bloody fight with you. Strong enough that I worry you might commit the blasphemy of defeating that person.”

I could see his eyes on me. Hear his voice.

And I could feel the pure admiration in them.

Along with…

The faint killing intent hidden beneath it.

“Your limitless potential and your sense of justice have moved me. I mean that.”

“…!”

“…!”

“…!”

It happened in an instant.

Jeok Cheongang and I sprang forward. So did Sama Pyo, who had stood silently by until then.

The order and timing of our push off the ground and our charge differed, but the desperation driving us was probably the same.

Crack.

Our toes gouged the earth. Sand crumbled.

Internal energy surged from my dantian into the muscles of my tensed lower body, then exploded.

Boom!

The world slowed. The scenery shifted.

We shot forward, closing the distance of over ten jang[3662].

In that moment, Jeok Cheongang and I were two fierce streaks of flame. Sama Pyo was a silent wind.

And in the slowed flow of time, three walls rose to block the flames and the wind.

“Ha!”

Three voices. One shout.

[3662] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

The Three Elders of Tianshan.

The three fiends of Tianshan unleashed their pent-up fury and energy, wielding a power too great for anyone to dismiss them as mere stray dogs.

A coordinated technique, honed over ages of working together, merged the three walls into one enormous barrier.

Boom!

A single clash shook heaven and earth.

Amid that tremendous roar and the rippling waves of power that filled a time already split into fragments, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's hand, raised toward the sky, finally came down.

Like countless blades waiting on a hillside for a single command.

"Slash!"

Shhk! Thk-thk-thk!

As a thousand or so heads rolled to the ground, my eyes met the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's. The blood in my body went cold.

He was smiling.

Chapter 1028

At that moment, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord was smiling.

Pure delight and excitement filled his crescent-shaped eyes. His long, vertically slit pupils trembled with anticipation for what was to come.

More precisely, with anticipation for one young man.

Yes. That's it. That's exactly the look.

Watching Jin Taekyung's eyes widen with shock and fury, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord felt his heart pound.

He had erased a thousand lives with a single gesture, yet he paid them no mind. All his senses were fixed on Jin Taekyung.

He felt not the slightest guilt for the dead, nor the slightest remorse for breaking his promise.

He had been born and raised in the Demonic Cult.

The cruelty he'd possessed since his mother's womb had blossomed through the demonic martial arts he'd learned from the time he could walk. Even among the twenty-four great fiends who served the Heavenly Demon, no one could match him.

Now, Jin Taekyung was the only thing that interested him.

The Divine Dragon of the Central Plains Murim, a rising star whom his master was watching closely.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord wanted to see everything about that young brat.

He wanted to feel the full extent of the martial prowess unleashed at his fingertips, the emotions pouring out of him, the something special hidden within.

Show me. Hurry!

And just as the Blood-Sword Demon Lord cried out in his heart—

Whooosh!

An immense, unprecedented energy surged up around one man.

"Who should I kill first?"

Jin Taekyung.

At the sight of the cold flames pouring from the young man's eyes, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's smile deepened.

The Three Elders of Tianshan's first reaction was suspicion.

Jin Taekyung held a spear that hadn't been there moments ago.

How?

The promise had come to nothing now, but one of the terms of their meeting had been to come unarmed. Jin Taekyung's side had honored that condition.

They had all arrived empty-handed, a considerable comfort to the Three Elders of Tianshan.

If they could handle the terrifying old monster called the Fire King, two weaponless young brats shouldn't be much trouble.

Even if one of them was the renowned Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung, the three elders were fiends of a bygone age whose infamy had spread from Tianshan to the Central Plains.

As far as they were concerned, it was a fight they could win.

At least, until a spear appeared in Jin Taekyung's hand.

Until an immense power, far beyond anything they had expected, enveloped that divine weapon, clearly made of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron.

Hummm.

The dazzling white spearhead trembled.

No—the air around it shuddered in tiny ripples.

At the same time, an immense, pure energy surged up and wrapped around the spearhead. It was far too vast to be contained in the body of a young man who had turned twenty only a few years ago.

Ssssss.

What people called Force was no longer a dazzling blue-white.

This is…

The three old men caught their breath without realizing it.

What could they even call this power?

The Force gathered at the spearhead was dark as the deep sea. It burned blue like fire at its fiercest, yet also flashed like a thunderbolt.

It's different.

The Three Elders of Tianshan felt it instinctively.

That energy was of a different kind, a different order, from the energy they had cultivated all their lives.

But they had no way of knowing what it truly was.

They did not know that the strange familiarity they felt came from the internal energy Jin Taekyung had received from the Heavenly Power Demon.

They did not know that the ominous power born of demonic martial arts had finally become one with the Fire Gate Clan's hellfire and the Hebei Peng Family's thunderbolt.

Nor did they know just how immense and keen the power within that dark-blue streak of light was.

The one person who understood all of it better than anyone stood beside Jin Taekyung.

Ah.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, watched Jin Taekyung, his gaze deep and still.

He had suspected as much. He simply hadn't confirmed it with his own eyes.

The summit of martial mastery.

The young man had reached the highest peak, one that touched the heavens. Age and experience were no longer measures by which to judge him.

He was a great martial artist who had forged a path of his own, one no one else had walked before.

Jeok Cheongang wanted to ask him, in all sincerity:

Do you know how remarkable the realm you've reached is?

And he wanted to tell him:

Across the Central Plains Murim, people gave those who reached such a realm a name spoken with the deepest respect.

The Ten Kings.

A vast, boundless sky and three stars.

Beneath them had stood ten giants.

And today, here and now, Jin Taekyung was proving himself the eleventh.

But he was different from those who had fallen to the passage of time or collapsed beneath their enemies' cold-blue blades, spilling their blood. He was a hero of a new age.

On this battlefield, where a thousand lives had been extinguished, an immense blaze was rising.

How dazzling you are.

A shiver ran down Jeok Cheongang's spine.

Then he looked at the Three Elders of Tianshan, staring at Jin Taekyung in a daze, and saw the shadow of death slowly falling over them.

"Old Master."

A quiet call, seething with pain at having failed to prevent so many deaths—and with the fury that pain had bred.

Jeok Cheongang spoke.

"Do as you've decided."

They didn't know those few, cryptic words were the trust and encouragement of a master to his Disciple, who was willing to risk his life.

Nor did they know that the brief exchange had sealed their fate.

Whoosh!

A sharp gust of wind swept through.

A dark-blue flash—impossible to tell whether it was flame, wave, or thunderbolt—distorted space as it rushed at them, impossibly fast and carrying tremendous force.

Slash!

Goose bumps rose across the First Elder's body. He twisted aside on instinct, but blood and terrible pain spread along the path of the strike.

"Gah!"

The flash had passed, and that was all.

If he hadn't glimpsed something indistinct at the last moment, his ghost would already be wandering the Nine Springs.

How? How could this…!

The First Elder gritted his teeth and barely held back the pain and shock. His face stricken, he clutched his deeply slashed chest and staggered backward.

Against such speed and power, retreat would only lead to death. Fortunately, he had two dependable sworn brothers.

"Elder Brother!"

"No!"

The Second and Third Elders cried out and charged. One wielded a saber, the other a sword. Their hands blurred as they swung at the same target.

Jin Taekyung, who had rushed at them with the ghostlike movements of an assassin.

KWAANG!

One spear against a saber and a sword.

The three weapons, carrying several jiazi[3663] of internal energy, collided with a terrible roar that shook everything around them.

The earth heaved. The air burst apart.

Amid waves of power more violently turbulent than anything they had ever felt, the two old men saw it clearly:

The cold flames pouring from Jin Taekyung's eyes. His hand gripping the spear shaft without the slightest tremor, even against two Supreme Peak masters.

And he was holding it with only one hand.

"Wa—"

Before the warning could leave their lips, Jin Taekyung's palm slammed into the Third Elder's chest.

Ah.

His vision swam. The Third Elder felt a terrible heat smash through bone and flesh and burrow deep inside him.

[3663] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle, used here to measure accumulated internal energy.

Crack.

The sickening sound came a moment later, faint as a distant echo. Blood surged into his mouth. As his body began to crumple, familiar shouts rang in his ears.

“You bastard!”

“Little Brother!”

No mistake. His elder brothers.

The world had called them fiends and bastards, but they had cherished him as if all three had been born of the same mother.

Crunch.

The Third Elder bit his tongue and forced his collapsing body upright.

He couldn’t fall here. He hadn’t survived this long to meet such a pointless end.

Besides…

We have the Demon Lord. We have his power.

The Third Elder was certain.

By now, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord must have stepped in.

He couldn’t see clearly through the haze in his mind, but surely a single command from the Demon Lord could free him from this terrible internal injury and pain.

But…

But why?

Why can’t I feel anything?

Even with his vision blurred, his senses as a Supreme Peak master remained. Yet as the Third Elder staggered and steadied himself, his Qi Sense told him everything was just as it had been.

Even while his two sworn brothers fought Jin Taekyung with all their might, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s presence remained where it had been, more than ten jang[3664] away.

“Demon Lord! Demon Lord!”

Crack! Boom!

The roar erupting from the spearhead swallowed the Third Elder’s desperate cry. But the Blood-Sword Demon Lord could not have failed to hear him.

Still, nothing changed.

No—that wasn’t quite true. Something did change.

It was tiny beside the immense energies surging all around them, and all the more stealthy for it.

Whish—thunk!

“…!”

The Third Elder’s body locked up.

[3664] A Korean *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

He felt a cold blade pierce his back, with saber qi gathered at its tip. He spun around in a flash and swung his arm.

Whoom—boom!

Compressed air exploded, but his blow struck nothing.

He stood frozen, staring at the empty air he had hit. Then someone's figure slowly came into focus.

Black clothes as dark as pitch. Calm eyes.

The young man looked barely thirty, yet his voice was so low and composed it was almost hard to believe.

"You should always watch your back. Leave an opening like that, and even I can't just stand by."

"You…!"

The Third Elder bit his lip hard enough to draw blood.

It wasn't the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang. It wasn't the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

It was the young brat he had ignored from the beginning—the one who had somehow kept a dagger hidden and now driven it into his back.

With a single surprise attack.

"And you still call yourself a man of the orthodox faction!"

It was a hollow accusation, without sense or grounds. Sama Pyo shrugged.

"That's all right. I'm from the unorthodox faction."

"…!"

"And one more thing."

Sama Pyo paused and casually flicked his hand.

Another flash came from the ample sleeve of his martial robe.

"I brought plenty of daggers."

Whish!

A sharp whistle drowned out his last quiet words.

Watching the streak of light fly straight toward him, the Third Elder sneered inwardly.

At least, until he realized he couldn't move. The terrible internal injury Jin Taekyung had dealt him and the dagger lodged in his back held him fast.

What is this…!

Thwack!

The dagger pierced the center of his forehead, and the Third Elder felt the world go dark.

The last thing he heard was Jeok Cheongang, who had watched it all, speaking.

"That's one. No, two."

The Third Elder, whose breath had already stopped, didn’t see it.

At the very moment his final breath left his body, the spearhead of White Flame, cloaked in dark-blue Force, sliced through the Second Elder’s throat.

Slash!

Beneath the fountain of blood, the First Elder’s eyes widened in horror. His body trembled.

Chapter 1029

Tap. Patter-patter.

Hot and damp.

Blood that had shot up like a fountain fell onto my head, soaking my scalp.

Someone who was already a headless corpse would never feel it again.

> **System** Defeated Lv. 135 Gungongbo!
> Acquired a large amount of Fame.
> Acquired a large amount of EXP.

Splatter!

A moment later, the body lost its balance and collapsed into the pool of blood.

The Second Elder's head had come off before he could even react. With a bewildered expression, it looked up at his sworn brothers.

Or rather, at the only sworn brother still in this world.

"One down. No—two."

Jeok Cheongang's words marked the Third Elder's end. I turned and saw a silver blade jutting from the back of the man sprawled like a rotten log.

Pssht.

Blood dripped in little spurts with a deflating hiss.

Sama Pyo pulled the dagger from between the dead Third Elder's brows. When our eyes met, he shrugged.

"Did I do something I shouldn't have?"

I answered.

"Yeah."

"If he was yours to deal with, I'm sorry. I thought leaving him alive might cause trouble…"

"That's not what I mean."

A question entered Sama Pyo's eyes. I let out a breath as hot as a ball of fire.

"You shouldn't have killed him so easily."

EXP didn't matter. Neither did whose hand killed him.

He should have suffered more.

He shouldn't have left this world so easily, in a single instant.

[3665] In traditional East Asian medicine, the Eight Extraordinary Meridians are channels distinct from the twelve primary meridians.

The Second Elder hadn’t. First his collarbone had been torn away, then one arm severed. Only after his Eight Extraordinary Meridians[3665] had been ripped to shreds did his head come off.

“Don’t step in again. Not one step.”

My voice sounded strange and desolate, as if it belonged to someone else.

I didn’t even know what I looked like right now.

But Sama Pyo’s and Jeok Cheongang’s grim, hardened expressions—and the First Elder, frozen as if he’d come face-to-face with a fiend—gave me some idea.

“M-monster…”

His body trembled. So did his voice.

In the eyes of the old fiend who had lost the two sworn brothers he’d spent his life with in the blink of an eye, I saw rage he couldn’t hide. And fear, deeper and darker still.

Splosh.

I took a slow step forward.

Maybe it was the blood soaking the ground, but my footfall sounded unusually loud. The First Elder flinched and stumbled backward.

No. He dragged himself back on his rear, bracing himself with both arms.

With both knees shattered, it was the only way he could put even a little distance between us.

“D-don’t come any closer! I said don’t!”

The First Elder flung out his arms with a scream.

Boom!

I turned my head before I even heard the rush of air. The manifested palm force blasted through the space where my head had been a moment earlier.

He was already half-crippled, but the powerful internal energy flowing deep within him still burned like an inextinguishable flame.

Of course…

“Do it again.”

To my eyes, his movements were clumsy beyond words and hopelessly slow. Every move was full of openings.

“Aaaaaah!”

I couldn’t tell whether it was a scream or a battle shout.

Bang! Bang! Boom!

Panicked, the First Elder unleashed palm force after palm force, bursting the compressed air around me.

The force of his attacks whipped my hair about and tore through my collar and skin.

And that was his final struggle.

Grab—crack!

I seized his wrist like lightning and twisted.

It wasn’t a grappling technique built on complex principles, or even a move powered by internal energy.

Just raw Strength and Agility.

That power and speed, far beyond human limits, crushed frail flesh and bone with ease.

“Ghk…!”

His face twisted with terrible pain. A stifled groan escaped him.

But I knew.

If the old fiend before me were the sort to give up after this much, the name Three Elders of Tianshan would have been forgotten long ago.

Whoosh! Crash!

Five fingers curled like hooks flashed down and struck the ground.

One step.

I read his movement and stepped back ahead of him. His hand barely grazed my collar before plunging deep into the earth. I stomped on the back of it.

Crack!

I felt the bones shatter beneath my sole, a thousand geun[3666] of weight behind it.

My calm face was reflected in his eyes, wide with pain and terror beyond anything he’d imagined.

“Don’t look at me like that.”

Thud.

I struck him squarely in the jaw. His head snapped to the side, and yellow teeth flew in every direction with the blood.

“When you look at me like that…”

Thud.

One more.

“Right now…”

Thud.

Again.

“It makes me want to kill you.”

Crack!

Sticky blood clung to my fist.

I grabbed the First Elder by the hair. He no longer moved at all. Slowly, I straightened up.

“We’re only just getting started, aren’t we?”

[3666] A thousand Korean *geun* is about 600 kg, or 1,320 lb.

I wasn't talking to the First Elder.

I was speaking to the monster watching from more than ten jang[3667] away, his face flushed—the one who had cut off a thousand heads with a single gesture.

Clap. Clap. Clap.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord applauded slowly, gazing at me with admiration.

"Magnificent. No—beautiful."

His answer made my blood run cold.

Even with rage consuming me, I hadn't expected anything like that reaction from him.

"That's how a Murim warrior ought to fight. Crush your opponent cruelly and completely. That's a real fight, don't you think?"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord was grinning from ear to ear.

Two of the Three Elders of Tianshan—valuable fighters who served as his own hands and feet—were dead, and the third was crippled. Yet he looked far happier than he had a moment ago.

"Crazy… bastard."

"Me? Or you?"

"What?"

"Well, isn't it true?"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord blinked at me, then spread his arms and turned in a slow circle.

"Look at me. My clothes are terribly drab, but compared to you, don't I look positively mild-mannered?"

"…!"

"Ah, don't misunderstand. I'm certainly not saying you look unpleasant. If anything, I find this rather familiar… It's a good sight, in more ways than one."

At his satisfied smile, I suddenly felt short of breath.

Familiar, he'd said. Pleasing.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord, of all people. That old, vicious fiend.

He was talking about me, drenched in blood from head to toe.

About the person I'd been a moment ago, consumed not merely by revenge but by the desire to inflict even greater pain.

"This… What I mean is…"

"Enough."

A voice I knew all too well cut me off. It was lower than usual.

"That's enough."

Jeok Cheongang strode forward, and I suddenly wanted to ask him something.

[3667] A *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m or 9.94 ft. Ten jang is about 30.3 m or 99.4 ft.

Who was he speaking to?

Me? Or the Blood-Sword Demon Lord?

Or both of us?

But I didn't ask. No—I couldn't.

For a moment, I was too afraid to ask whether I'd looked like a fiend mad with blood and revenge.

And yet, ironically, it was that very fiend who helped me steady my stiffened body and mind.

"To interrupt us at a time like this, Senior. That's cruel of you. We were having quite a meaningful conversation."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord shook his head. Jeok Cheongang spat onto the ground.

"Fuck off. This old man has never had a junior like you."

"I know. But I've admired you for so long that I can't help myself. I'll have to settle for loving you from afar."

"Do I have to turn you into charcoal while you're still alive to shut that mouth of yours?"

"Probably. To be honest, I was a little disappointed about that. I thought at least one of those three would end up that way."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord gave a showy sigh, then continued.

"You have no idea how excited I was when I heard what happened at Mount Jiuhua all those years ago. A descendant of the Fire Gate Clan I'd only ever heard about! And when I heard those fools who dared lay a hand on you had all been reduced to ash—how satisfying that was."

"What did you say?"

"Well, isn't it? Burned alive—imagine the pain they must have felt. What revenge could be more certain or more terrible?"

"…!"

"Everyone else shuddered and called you a mad old man. Not me. I've admired you ever since."

His eyes shone like the morning star. Jeok Cheongang and I were speechless. Even Sama Pyo, who had been watching everything calmly, seemed at a loss for words.

A fiend.

More than anyone I'd ever met, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord deserved the word. He was a madman.

Now I understood better than ever why "blood" was part of his title.

And to him, the Three Elders of Tianshan were no more than livestock he'd kept close at hand.

“Those idiots, too. During the Great Faction War, the moment a battle started going against them, they couldn’t run fast enough. Today they stepped forward without knowing their place, so they deserved to die… Ah, come to think of it, one’s still alive.”

Wheeze, wheeze.

“D-Demon Lord…”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord glanced at the First Elder, who was still drawing shallow breaths, then looked at me.

“I only ask out of concern, but you aren’t thinking of letting him live, are you?”

“Why do you ask?”

“He’s been bothering me for a while. Neither alive nor dead… Better to settle it one way or the other, don’t you think?”

“…!”

“If you’re going to kill him, do it quickly. If you want a prisoner, have that young fellow beside you take him back. He doesn’t know much, though, so he won’t be much use.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord gestured toward Sama Pyo, then smacked his lips.

“Ah, though perhaps there isn’t time for that anymore.”

Boom. Boom. Bwoom.

The war drums were drawing closer, each beat louder and deeper than the last.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord and us.

Behind each side, the aura of countless troops made the air tremble.

Now it begins.

I could feel it.

The bloody battle for the Great Snow Mountain—the great battle we could no longer avoid—had finally begun.

And…

I can end it right here.

I couldn’t tell exactly how strong the Blood-Sword Demon Lord was, but Jeok Cheongang and I should be enough.

Now that the Three Elders of Tianshan, a core part of the enemy’s strength, were gone, the balance of this battle had tipped heavily in our favor.

Surely.

Surely that was how it would go.

Then why…

Why had the Blood-Sword Demon Lord only watched?

Why had he treated three Supreme Peak masters—fighters that valuable—like livestock?

This is…

The moment that thought came to me, my eyes widened.

Whoosh!

Dark clouds had gathered without my noticing. A cold fiercer than the Great Snow Mountain's own approached, freezing the wind as it came.

And at the center of it all, a company of riders swept toward us like dark mist.

Sssaaaaa.

Not even a pounding of hooves accompanied their ghostlike charge. Watching them, I thought of the otherworldly beings who should never have appeared here, in Murim.

"Death Knights…?"

Chapter 1030

The absurd had invaded common sense long ago.

Laws had been broken, truths overturned, and the word *death* had become cheap.

At least, that was the world one young man had been born and raised in.

Monsters. Hunters.

Monsters and humans killing one another inside the boundaries between dimensions known as Gates.

Mana and magical power.

Miraculous forces that shattered truths Earth had held since ancient times, along with laws discovered by the handful of geniuses who had shaped human history.

And a war that still hadn't ended.

The young man was part of that world.

A world where Magic tore open the earth, rained down fire and lightning, and defied gravity.

Where Hunters shone with dazzling auras as they faced monsters of grotesque appearance and unimaginable strength—creatures found only in ancient myths, or beyond anything anyone had ever imagined.

Humans were adaptable creatures.

By the time the little child born on the day humanity won its great victory was approaching thirty, the absurdity that had overturned the world in the Great Cataclysm had become the new common sense.

Until another absurdity changed everything.

On a steep hill in the middle of summer, beside the recycling area outside a goshiwon[3668], lay a massive hunk of scrap metal.

No—a VR capsule. An entrance to another world.

That was how a young man with nothing to his name stepped into a new world.

So much awaited him beyond the invisible veil.

Dangers and opportunities unlike any he'd known, and rewards.

He formed bonds with good people, fought countless enemies, and grew because of it.

That was why he wished so desperately for one thing:

That nothing out of the ordinary would happen here.

Perhaps that wish was why he kept downplaying and ignoring the one suspicion that grew stronger with time.

Until this very moment, when he faced the truth he hadn't wanted to believe.

"Death Knights…?"

[3668] A goshiwon is a very small, inexpensive room-for-rent arrangement in South Korea.

The words slipped vacantly from his parted lips.

The young man—Jin Taekyung—lifted his head and stared.

Caught by the word he himself had spoken.

Overwhelmed by the unbelievable sight before him.

Sssaaaaa.

Beneath the dark clouds hanging over the snow-covered mountains, a murky haze spread.

At its center, seven ghost horses soundlessly charged forward, stepping on empty air. On their backs sat seven men dressed not in armor that covered them from head to toe, but in black clothes as dark as pitch.

No. What he sensed was the unmistakably familiar presence of death.

Its essence never changed, whatever form it took.

The deep, cloying aura of death and its stench reached every one of Jin Taekyung's senses—even his soul.

No mistake.

Jin Taekyung trembled without realizing it.

He'd been right. It was them.

Death Knights.

Knights who had given up their souls and forsaken their rest.

The absurdity of another world was invading common sense once again.

Yet amid the two vast armies advancing toward each other, Jin Taekyung was the only one who recognized it.

"Retreat! Fall back, now—!"

Whoosh!

As he shouted to his allies, Jin Taekyung felt every hair on his body stand on end. He spun around.

He'd made that movement a thousand times—no, more than ten thousand.

Urgent, yet perfectly practiced, it followed the turn of his waist and arms. Dark-blue Force rose like a tidal wave.

KWAANG!

A deafening boom shook the air. Beyond the gray-white sword blade trembling against his spearpoint, a fiend gone mad with blood grinned at Jin Taekyung.

"Why not surrender while you still can?"

"I'll return those words to you."

The reply hadn't come from Jin Taekyung.

Jeok Cheongang had become a streak of light, closing on the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's flank. His palm struck ahead of his quiet voice.

Whooosh.

Flames erupted in a dazzling burst of heat.

Faced with the terrible heat of the Flame Divine Palm, which burned the air and melted ten-thousand-year snow, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord twisted aside without hesitation.

BOOM!

Compressed air exploded. No—it vaporized on the spot.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord narrowly avoided the palm strike and sprang backward. By any measure, it was a successful dodge, but the heat had still scorched his collar and the skin beneath it black.

“Whoops. Well, look at that.”

Burning pain was said to be worse than any other.

Yet even with his skin charred and parts of it melted, a smile remained on the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s lips.

“Just as they said, you’re a fiery one, Senior.”

“You bastard…!”

“Don’t be so angry. I may speak this way, but it stings me too.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord wasn’t trying to provoke him. He meant it.

They had clashed only once, but he knew one thing for certain.

He could never defeat the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, alone.

And even if Jeok Cheongang—a master half a step above him—weren’t there, capturing Jin Taekyung alive rather than killing him would be extremely difficult.

Of course, that was only how things stood for now.

“I should ask your understanding in advance for what’s about to happen, Senior. Yours too, my friend. I’m not entirely fond of doing things this way myself…”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had furrowed his brow as if he were troubled, but soon he burst into hearty laughter and continued.

“But what can I do? This, too, is part of proving that person’s greatness.”

At that moment—

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The vast army of Dark Heaven had already charged to within roughly three hundred thirty yards. More precisely, the seven pairs of riders at the head of the countless fanatics rose into the air, stepping on empty space.

No—they ran.

Screee!

Everyone advancing to meet them saw it clearly.

Tens of thousands of eyes widened. Tightly closed lips parted of their own accord.

Shock. Fear.

Only those two emotions showed in their eyes and on their faces.

What could anyone call such a sight?

Stepping on Empty Air? Traversing the Void?

No word that came to mind could quite explain it.

Several masters on the Murim Alliance's side were skilled enough in body-lightness techniques to step on empty air. But running through the sky *on horseback* was something none of them had ever imagined.

One person, however, was different.

They're coming.

Jin Taekyung tightened his grip on White Flame.

The sight had shocked him more than anyone else on the battlefield, but he also understood what he was seeing more clearly than anyone.

Familiar, yet strange.

Called Death Knights in the modern world, these beings—whatever they might be called in Murim—were closing in at blinding speed.

They're strong. These aren't ordinary ones.

Jin Taekyung could tell that more than their appearance had changed.

The closer they came, the stronger their stench and aura of death grew. Both far surpassed anything he knew from ordinary Death Knights.

Right. This is like…

Lei Fei.

Jin Taekyung suddenly remembered another hero whose soul, not so long ago, had been forcibly corrupted by an Arch Lich.

The Death Knight Lord.

Lei Fei had been an S-rank Hunter and a hero. In his corrupted state, he had been the strongest enemy they faced after the Arch Lich itself.

A chosen leader among Death Knights, who had not only retained all his strength from life but grown stronger still.

A Named Monster fully deserving of the title *Lord*.

Yet each of the seven men in black riding ghost horses at the head of the enemy army gave off an aura no weaker than Lei Fei's had been.

No. Stronger.

It was already too late to turn back.

Fear was contagious.

His allies' morale had soared as they watched him defeat the Three Elders of Tianshan in an instant. Now, faced with something they had never seen or heard of, it was fading like a bubble.

He drew our entire army out of the Great Snow Mountain. He used the Three Elders of Tianshan as bait.

Jin Taekyung understood at last.

The Three Elders of Tianshan had been used as bait from the very beginning, for this exact moment.

And the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's plan had worked perfectly.

Even if their allies retreated now, the enemy would reach them all the faster.

Jin Taekyung had only two choices left.

Hold this position so his shaken allies could retreat before they ever crossed weapons with the enemy.

Or…

Risk everything and turn this around.

At his side stood the one person he trusted and could follow more than anyone.

"How many will you take?"

"All eight."

Jin Taekyung gave a quiet laugh at Jeok Cheongang's calm answer.

"That'll be tough at your age."

"Don't worry. Ever since I got younger, I've had energy to spare."

"I'm glad that Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng I brought you was worth it."

"That little thing? Bring me Ten-Thousand-Year Snow Ginseng next time."

"Have you no shame?"

"Want to open me up and check?"

The Fire Gate Clan's master and disciple stood like iron towers at the heart of the battlefield, waiting for the enemy.

About a hundred sixty-five yards away, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord watched them, his face flushed with excitement. The vast army behind him surged past its commander and poured toward them.

"They're swarming like a pack of dogs. Even the unorthodox faction would have to give them that."

At Jeok Cheongang's mutter, Sama Pyo let out a dry laugh.

"Yes. I think so too."

"Come to think of it, there's an unorthodox brat right here."

"I can't deny that."

"Unorthodox, you say. Is that truly how you see yourself?"

"This hardly seems the time to answer that, but what can I do? I was born, and the whole world called me unorthodox. I suppose that's my lot."

About a hundred yards.

The enemy's shouts shook the air from every direction, making their ears ring. Sama Pyo tightened his grip on the sword and saber that had once belonged to the Three Elders of Tianshan, one in each hand.

"That's the stupidest thing I've heard. Are you an idiot?"

At the quiet voice in his ear, Sama Pyo's body stiffened.

"What… did you say?"

"I asked if you're an idiot. You."

About sixty-five yards.

As the aura of tens of thousands of enemies made the air tremble, Jin Taekyung went on calmly.

"You live the way you were born, let other people decide what to call you, and go along with it? Is that your life?"

"That's…"

"Just live however the hell you want. Protect what needs protecting. Do something good now and then. What does it matter whether you're part of the orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction, or the dark-path figures?"

Sama Pyo's face went rigid.

His words came so freely. That made them hurt all the more—and made Sama Pyo envy him.

Unlike Sama Pyo, Jin Taekyung had been born into the orthodox faction.

"What do you know about me to say something like that?"

"Of course I don't know shit. How would I know what kind of life you've lived? You've never told me."

"What?"

"But I know what kind of person you are."

About thirty yards.

Clouds gathered overhead. Darkness fell.

Watching the shadows descend through the empty air, Jin Taekyung tossed out one short sentence.

"We're here together now."

"…!"

"I guess I'm pretty good at judging people. Right, Old Master?"

Jeok Cheongang didn't answer, and Jin Taekyung didn't wait for him to.

About a year earlier, the Pavilion Master of the Fire Dragon Pavilion had gladly welcomed the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate when he'd come calling out of the blue.

Now Jin Taekyung swung the spear in his hand.

Whooosh.

A dark-blue tidal wave rose, hot as hellfire and swift as a thunderbolt.

And as Jin Taekyung advanced without hesitation, Sama Pyo suddenly thought he looked dazzling.

KWA-BOOM!

Chapter 1031

I didn’t wonder if I could do it.

I had to. I had to see it through.

Power came with responsibility, and the weight of that responsibility wouldn’t let me take even one step back.

That was why I was moving forward now.

Whoosh.

I lowered the First Elder, still in my grip, and planted my foot on the ground. In the same instant, I shot forward.

Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step.

The subtle art I’d learned from the greatest assassin of all time flowed through my feet.

My legs felt impossibly light. Wind brushed past me, then vanished without a trace in the heat radiating from someone nearby.

The moment I tightened my grip on the spear shaft—

Swaaash!

The world slowed.

Seven streams of Force fell like lightning from overhead. Jeok Cheongang and I flung out our hands at the same time.

KWA-BOOOOM!

A crash that seemed to split the sky rang out, and time, paused for an instant, surged forward like a raging torrent.

KRRRUNCH!

The ground flipped over from the force of the collision. My feet, light as air only moments ago, were driven back under a pressure of tens of thousands of pounds.

Damn it.

I felt the difference in strength the instant we collided, and my teeth clenched before I could stop them.

I’d expected them to be strong. Not this strong.

Seven.

Not one, not two, not three—but seven Death Knights.

No, the men in black were far too powerful. They hadn’t merely kept all their former strength; they’d grown stronger still.

Even with Jeok Cheongang at my side, their power was too much to withstand.

“Hngh…!”

A muffled breath came from right beside me.

Jeok Cheongang was holding off four enemies alone, proving his title as the Fire King. But this momentary standoff was like a glass bottle on the verge of shattering.

Just as it was now.

SHWING! KRAANG!

The three spears and swords, shrouded in pitch-black Force, met the White Flame's blade once more. The impact left me gasping, and I felt my knees bend on their own.

They're strong. The Three Elders of Tianshan don't even compare.

The Three Elders had certainly been powerful masters. But inheriting the Thunderbolt Saber King's internal energy and gaining insight weren't the only reasons I'd been able to defeat them alone.

Sometimes a pack of wolves was more frightening than a single tiger.

The Three Elders had built their infamy as a pack, much like the Qilian Three Fiends, who had followed the Western Heaven Demon Lord and drenched Sichuan in blood.

But the men in black, closing in on me with tremendous strength and momentum even now, were different.

They were tigers.

Unlike the Three Elders of Tianshan, each one could command an entire mountain range—or, at least, they must have been able to in the past.

The worst part was that these tigers had lost their souls, grown even stronger, and now moved as a pack at one man's command.

"How do they seem, now that you've faced them yourself? Impressive, aren't they? I call them Black Ghosts."

Behind the seven men in black—the seven Black Ghosts—the enemy's vast army drew closer with every passing moment. Even over its roar, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's voice rang clear.

So did his aura, growing more intense with each slow step.

"Don't struggle too hard. It's a shame about Senior Jeok, but that can't be helped. You, on the other hand, are a very important prize."

I couldn't see his face behind the Black Ghosts, but I could picture it, if only faintly.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord smiling. His eyes bright with excitement at the sea of corpses and blood to come.

"Who knows? If you surrender quietly now, perhaps both master and disciple can survive."

Grrk. Grrrk!

Under the crushing pressure, I barely managed to force out my voice.

"Fuck… off!"

KWAANG!

I thrust the spear shaft upward. All three of their spears and swords flew into the air at once.

Four jiazi[3669] of internal energy and a body far beyond human limits let me throw off the Black Ghosts' combined attack, strengthened though they were at the cost of their souls. Only for a moment.

But that moment gave me an opening I wouldn't get again.

SHHK!

I swung with all my strength and cut through them.

More precisely, I cut three huge black horses in half—ghost horses, powerful monsters in their own right.

FWOOOSH!

Instead of the blood any living creature should have had, a dark mist burst out. Jeok Cheongang, who'd been barely holding on, gaped at the unbelievable sight.

"What kind of fucked-up—!"

I'd have liked to explain, but now wasn't the time.

The Black Ghosts lost their balance as their mounts vanished beneath them. I seized the chance and charged the four facing Jeok Cheongang.

SHK-SHK! KAKAKANG!

I slashed, stabbed, and struck.

They blocked all three lightning-fast attacks without difficulty. Waiting for them, though, was Jeok Cheongang's palm strike, wreathed in brilliant white flames.

"Die."

Whoosh—BOOM!

The Flame Divine Palm shot forward without even a sound of rushing air and struck one of the Black Ghosts.

The man took the blow square in the chest and flew back like a cannonball. Jeok Cheongang bared his teeth in a grin.

Or tried to.

"Good. That's one—"

—Grrr.

The Black Ghost should have died, his whole body scorched black. Instead, he let out a strange groan and straightened up.

"…No, it isn't."

Perhaps the Flame Divine Palm's force still lingered. Jeok Cheongang stared blankly as the Black Ghost staggered to his feet, then blinked at me.

"What the hell are those things?"

[3669] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle; four jiazi are 240 years.

KWAANG!

I parried a Black Ghost's sword and let out a breath before answering.

"Death. Death Knights."

"Great Hand, Great Hand, Shift-Head? What the hell are you talking about?"

Unfortunately, I couldn't clear up Jeok Cheongang's confusion.

Before I could say another word, all the Black Ghosts charged at once, including the one Jeok Cheongang had knocked away.

KWA-BOOOOM!

My ears rang. Pain shot through my wrist, and both my legs sank deep into the ground.

The pressure was terrifying, as if Taishan itself were bearing down on me.

And just as Jeok Cheongang and I were trapped in a forest of steel, a fierce rush of air sounded from somewhere.

Whoosh—CLANG-CLANG!

A Black Ghost's great saber knocked away a dozen or so throwing knives. I could guess who'd been fool enough to join this fight.

Sama Pyo. You idiot. What the hell are you doing here?

But there was only a hair's breadth between courage and stupidity.

Sama Pyo was an idiot, but he was brave. He'd distracted only one of them, yet even that gave us a little room to breathe.

"Old Master, now!"

"Damn it!"

Jeok Cheongang spat a curse and shot out his fist like lightning.

KRRRUNCH!

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

Flames erupted like an explosion, pushing back the weapons wrapped in black Force, if only for a moment.

The earth-shaking blast rattled everything for hundreds of feet. It also concealed a streak of light racing through the flames.

SHWING! THUNK!

A throwing knife left Sama Pyo's hand and sank into a Black Ghost's throat. The blade quivered.

Of course, I knew better than anyone that it wouldn't be enough to bring him down.

Pshk.

The Black Ghost pulled out the knife as though it were nothing. I took advantage of the brief gap in their encirclement to leap back.

"You asked earlier what a Death Knight was."

"…"

"They're bastards like that."

"…Shit. This is a fine mess."

Jeok Cheongang sighed. Sama Pyo came up beside us, his face calm.

"What monsters."

"Idiot. You should've fallen back earlier. What, did you come all this way for a good view?"

"I already regret it. But what exactly are they? Some kind of jiangshi?"

"Similar, but let's say they're a bit worse."

Jiangshi would be a thousand times better.

If they were a Maoshan Sect specialty, at least the people of this world could call them native creatures.

But these Death Knights—the Black Ghosts—were an invasive species.

They would destroy the ecosystem and shatter every law and bit of common sense.

No. They already had.

How could this happen…?

I swallowed a quiet groan.

How it was possible no longer mattered.

The rules we'd all believed in had already crumbled, and now we had to deal with the wreckage.

That's right. Not just a handful of us. *All* of us.

Rumble, rumble.

The ground trembled. The shouts that had shaken everything around us were now at my back, drawing up beside Jeok Cheongang and Sama Pyo.

"Infinite Life Buddha."

The one approaching with a low invocation was the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord.

Beside him stood the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword, who had studied under the same master, along with nearly a thousand disciples of the Zhongnan Sect.

And there was another man, his face set hard.

"So it comes to this."

The Black Night King, Sima Gong.

He commanded countless martial artists from Gansu—numbers in no way inferior to the enemy's. His somber gaze rested on us.

No. On Sama Pyo.

His lips parted as though he meant to speak, but in the end he said nothing. He looked ahead instead, toward the rulers from beyond the desert, finally facing us on this vast snowfield.

“Enough.”

The Black Ghosts advancing silently toward us stopped as one. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord stepped out among them, an army of tens of thousands at his back.

Thud.

“Good. This is how you should meet me.”

Vrrrrm.

The gray-white blade trembled. Its color hardly suited the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s title, though it had reaped carnage that ranked among the worst of the Great Faction War.

Dark-red Force welled from it, the surges joining and binding together without pause as he leveled the sword at the people in his way.

It was too late for us to turn back. All we could do was press forward with everything we had.

WAAAAAH!

Shouts and killing intent, fear and anger, mingled and swelled.

Amid that violent whirl of emotion, I took a slow step forward.

Crunch.

Cold. Frost broke beneath my toes.

Thump.

My heart beat.

I quickened my steps to match its harsh, rapid rhythm.

Whoosh. SHWAAAAA!

The wind blew. The mild breeze became a raging gale, and I summoned that gale.

No—the whole battlefield did.

WAAAAAH!

Shouts, clouds, wind.

Beyond them, countless blades flashed.

And two vast armies raced across the dazzling white snowfield, colliding at last in its center.

KRRRUNCH!

The white snow turned red.

Through the blood mist as it billowed and spread, through countless screams and deaths, the superhumans shot toward one another.

Chapter 1032

It was like watching two enormous waves swallow each other.

There were a few differences. This was a vast snowy plain, not the sea. The waves were made of countless people and flashing blades, not water. And the spray thrown up by their collision was red as blood.

No—it was blood itself.

KRRRUNCH!

Tens of thousands clashed with tens of thousands.

Like warhorses that had never learned to retreat, the two armies charged straight at each other and tangled together in an instant, weapons flashing in their hands.

CLANG! THUNK!

SHING!

A dense mist of blood spread through the air with the dreadful sound of blades cutting flesh.

And through the snowy plain, already awash with blood and screams, spearheads drove fiercely toward the heart of the battle.

“Infinite Life Buddha…”

Whoooosh.

The hem of a Daoist robe whipped violently, as if caught in a storm, under the force of an overwhelming aura.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had split five enemies apart with a single stroke. Now he brought his sword down at an angle, its blade enlarged by milky-white Force.

Swaaash!

The sheer pressure warped the space around it. A towering blade of Sword Force swept through the enemies clad in black armor.

KWA-BOOOOM!

The ground heaved with a deafening crash, and flesh and bone scattered in every direction.

Yet even after witnessing the grisly sight from point-blank range, the followers who had begun worshiping a new god called the Lord of Heaven didn’t so much as blink.

No—more precisely, they kept advancing, gazing at the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord with hazy eyes as though entranced.

All the while, they murmured their eight-character creed without pause.

“In heaven and on earth.”

“All demons bow in submission…”

CRUNCH!

Their hollow, almost chilling voices ended only when they died.

At least, that was what the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord believed in that moment.

Gurgle.

Blood bubbled in a follower's slashed throat.

His neck had been cut by the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's sword, yet he went on muttering as the light slowly faded from his eyes.

"Heaven above… gurgle… hea…"

THUNK!

The creed stopped only when the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord drove his sword into the man's chest. A chill ran down his spine.

They're no ordinary people.

Of course they weren't. Even when the Heavenly Demon swept across the Central Plains, the hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path gathered under him had been half-mad fanatics.

But the enemies the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had faced back then had at least known fear.

They, too, had possessed an emotion every human ought to have.

But what in the world…

Then he understood what had felt so familiar.

Fear.

They had no fear.

Though they clearly knew he was a stronger opponent they could never defeat, the followers of Dark Heaven kept surging toward him as though they had been born for this very moment.

Spraying red blood instead of white sea foam.

Screeeee!

The tip of his sword swept toward the enemies closing in from every direction.

The Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords.

The Zhongnan Sect's signature sword art, a technique of Supreme Peak mastery, swept through the space around him. Weapons and bodies met its razor-sharp Force and were cut apart like tofu, their pieces scattering across the snow.

SHING! THUD-THUD!

Corpses collapsed amid the sickening sounds of torn flesh.

Yet one enemy, his chest deeply cut along with one arm, didn't crumple with a groan of pain. He reached out with his one remaining hand.

BOOM!

A sharp whistle split the air, and the hem of the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's robe burst apart.

He narrowly avoided the palm strike and thrust out his hand at blinding speed.

THUNK!

Only after the Zhongnan Sect's famed Heavenly Vault Finger Qi pierced the man between the brows did he collapse.

But though he had dispatched dozens of enemies in less than a moment, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's face remained rigid.

This is…

There was no doubt. They had no fear, and they could barely feel pain.

He didn't know whether some secret technique or a drug that clouded the mind was responsible, but this was far beyond the bounds of common sense.

And there were tens of thousands of them.

They felt neither fear nor pain, and each was a skilled martial artist. They were weapons made to sweep across a battlefield.

This is bad. No—this is the worst.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord bit his lip, feeling a fear he hadn't known since the Great Faction War. Then—

Swoooosh!

Along with a rush of overlapping whistles, an immense force tore into one side of the battlefield.

KWA-BOOOOM!

A sudden crash sent countless scraps of flesh flying in every direction.

The Zhongnan Sect disciples had formed a tight sword formation around the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword. Now the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord watched it shatter in an instant, his eyes wide.

"No!"

"J-Junior Sister!"

Their cries were almost screams.

Stunned by the loss of fellow disciples they had known since childhood, they stared blankly at the enemy who had broken their formation with a single blow.

Two men covered in pitch black from head to toe.

No—the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had called them Black Ghosts, and the name suited these unknown beings all too well.

Sssaaaaa.

Black energy rose in threads around their bodies, swallowing the air.

The Zhongnan Sect disciples began to tremble without realizing it. The energy gripped their hearts and locked their limbs.

"Hngh…"

Strained breaths escaped all around.

Everyone was crushed beneath their chilling aura—an overwhelming force known as *Fear* somewhere far away.

No—almost everyone.

SHWOOF!

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord closed the distance in an instant, more furious than he had ever been.

Dozens of disciples had died in the blink of an eye.

The people he was duty-bound to protect as Sect Leader—the future pillars of the Zhongnan Sect, whom he had watched grow since childhood—had been cut down in an instant.

“How dare you!”

SHWING-SHWING-SHWING!

His sword tip cut through the air, driven by fury. The Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords, honed to nine-tenths mastery, sent dozens of sword images pouring forth.

Then they vanished without a trace.

Whoooosh! CLANG!

The moment those immense forces collided, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord’s eyes widened.

His beloved sword, which had cut through the wind, was being knocked aside by an axe blade swinging with the wind, erasing his sword images as it swept through them.

“What is this…!”

GRRRK. KWAANG!

Before the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord could finish his cry of shock, the blade finally gave way to the immense force and was sent flying. It trembled violently.

KRRUNCH!

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord slid back, his foot carving a deep furrow in the ground. He barely steadied himself, pain stabbing through his wrist.

Far worse than the pain was the shock.

“Y-You…”

The words stumbled from his lips.

He stared at the Black Ghost gripping a battle axe as large as a grown man, his eyes so wide they seemed ready to pop out.

No. It can’t be.

He tried to deny it, but there was no denying what stood before him.

The Black Ghost who had stopped the Zhongnan Sect Leader single-handedly had a face he remembered.

He hadn’t recognized it at first. Now he did.

That crude, strangely shaped weapon. Those features, horribly twisted and discolored, yet still faintly recognizable.

“…Black Axe Fiend.”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord murmured the name, stunned.

A great fiend of the Demonic Cult whom he and his master had faced on the battlefield long ago. A Supreme Peak master who had first taught him the fear of death.

And…

"He should have died."

One of the twenty-four great fiends under the Heavenly Demon, who had met his end right there on that day.

"Then… how?"

It was impossible. It should never have happened.

But the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's questions went unanswered.

A fierce rush of air swept toward him, dragging him back to the present.

Screeeee—CRUNCH!

A neck was severed. Blood sprayed into the air.

A middle-aged first-generation disciple, one marked as a future Elder, lost his head in a single stroke. Gritting his teeth, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord kicked off the ground.

"Senior Brothers!"

His shout carried internal energy. The Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword, frozen after belatedly recognizing the Black Axe Fiend, finally moved.

Fwoosh!

Their figures blurred, their movement techniques making their feet as light as feathers.

But the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's heart was heavy as he shot toward the Black Axe Fiend, returned from death as a Black Ghost, and the other Black Ghost beside him, whose aura was no less immense.

Could it be? Could it be…

Today might be the day.

He had long since joined the ranks of the superhuman. And though his two Senior Brothers were poor Daoists, they were fine martial artists.

So why?

Why did he fear those two enemies, even with his Senior Brothers and nearly a thousand disciples at his side?

…Infinite Life Buddha.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord thought of death. He had prepared himself for it when he left Mount Zhongnan, yet still could not easily accept it. He thrust out his sword.

SHWAAASH!

A murky-black axe blade swung to meet the sword strike warping the space around it.

KWA-BOOOOM!

The impact far exceeded anything he had expected. In that instant, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord understood.

His misgivings had not come from fear alone.

He was not the one who could decide the outcome of this battle.

KRRUNCH.

The world seemed to slow. Watching the sword that had been with him all his life shatter to pieces, he suddenly thought of someone.

Someone who was not the strongest person in the world, but who had always brought winds of change no one could have predicted.

A young man who kept moving ahead of everyone else.

Jin Daoist Friend.

At that very moment—

KWA-BOOOOM!

A wave of magical power, darker than storm clouds and thick as blood, swept in every direction.

Rumble…

At some point, a distant crash rang out from somewhere behind me. I forced my head to stay facing forward, even as instinct urged me to turn.

Swoosh—thunk!

An arrow passed my side by a finger's breadth and buried itself in an enemy approaching from my blind spot.

The arrow had clearly carried internal energy, but the bastard charged at me as if he hadn't felt a speck of pain. Crimson Saber Force gathered along his crescent saber as he swung it.

No—tried to swing it.

Thwack!

My foot snapped out a beat ahead of him. I felt his shin bones shatter beneath the kick.

He was plainly out of the fight.

But I didn't stop there. I flung out one hand at the bastard, slumped to the ground with his shin crushed.

Inventory open. Summon.

A dagger appeared in my empty hand and flew the instant my fingers closed around it. Its flashing tip went straight between his brows.

Thud. Thump!

By the time I heard him fall, I'd already moved another three *jang*[3670] ahead.

Beside me was the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Flames hungrily devoured everything in their path. Flesh melted in the terrible heat.

All around us, steam and a foul stench drowned out the screams. Then a fierce rush of air reached my ears.

Screeeee!

[3670] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to 10 *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Three *jang* are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

Chapter 1033

Every martial art contains at least dozens of movements, each with its own principles.

But no matter what martial art you've learned, there are ultimately only two ways to deal with an enemy's attack.

Block it, or dodge it.

And in that moment, I chose the latter.

KWA-BOOOOM! KRRRUNCH!

A flash came hurtling in with a fierce whistle and slammed into the ground.

The earth buckled as if an earthquake had struck, and a tremendous shock wave swept through the area.

At least a dozen enemies were caught in its wake and vanished without a trace. I'd escaped with only a few scratches from flying bits of rock, yet a chill ran down my spine.

Fast. And powerful.

It was hard to believe a javelin thrown from so far away could move that fast and hit that hard.

Dodging had hardly been a choice. I'd had no other option.

If I'd met it with a counterattack, that alone would have cost me a considerable amount of strength.

Jeok Cheongang, standing beside me, knew it too.

"I suspected as much, but those bastards certainly don't have ordinary internal energy."

Jeok Cheongang muttered in a low voice and clenched his fist.

Following his gaze, I saw four ghost horses approaching, each carrying a rider as they stepped through the air.

"Four, huh? How many passed us by earlier?"

The Great Snow Mountain region might not be as vast as the Qilian Mountains, but it was still enormous.

The frost-covered land at the foot of the mountain was broad enough for a battle like this, with countless enemies and allies tangled together. Jeok Cheongang and I had punched through the enemy lines ahead of everyone else like a single awl, but we couldn't stop them all.

Besides, the surest way to win a battle was to cut off the head, not the body.

"If I saw right, two."

I recalled the distant crash and tremor that had reached me before the javelin came flying.

Judging by their direction and distance…

"I think those two headed toward the Zhongnan Sect."

The Zhongnan Sect numbered only a thousand among our thirty thousand, but every one of them was an elite disciple of the main sect, not a lay affiliate. With three Supreme Peak masters among them, they were a formidable force.

If the enemy wanted to secure victory, stopping them would be crucial.

"Then that makes five, counting the ones who've just appeared."

We'd already let two slip past, and now four more had shown up.

But as far as we knew, there were seven of these monsters called Death Knights—or Black Ghosts—in all.

I adjusted my grip on White Flame and murmured, "One's unaccounted for."

"Then the last one…"

"Either guarding the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, or headed toward the Gansu martial artists led by Sima Gong. If it isn't the latter…"

I let my voice trail off, but Jeok Cheongang already knew about Sima Gong's suspicious behavior. He needed no further explanation.

"Then Sima Gong, that damned unorthodox bastard, has thrown in his lot with Dark Heaven."

Exactly.

A Black Ghost not going after Sima Gong's forces wouldn't prove it on its own. But there was no denying it would make betrayal far more likely.

If I were the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, I wouldn't bother sending a Black Ghost to Sima Gong if he was already an ally.

Especially…

With forces like these.

I watched the Black Ghosts draw closer, radiating a terrifying aura.

Armed with a saber, a sword, a spear, and a chain sickle, they sprang over the heads of the advancing enemy soldiers and shot toward us.

Each was a Supreme Peak master powerful enough to shake an entire city. They felt neither pain nor emotion, and their ability to recover was beyond human.

No—they were monsters through and through. Strange beings the likes of which no one in Murim had ever encountered.

"Old Master."

"Nothing more to say."

KRRUNCH!

Jeok Cheongang smashed the head of an enemy charging at him with soulless eyes in a single punch. Then he went on.

"I don't know what kind of monsters those things are, but we'll just keep killing them until they're dead."

The instant those quiet words left his lips—

Pop.

We kicked off the ground together and shot forward, striking with all our strength.

I swept out White Flame's spearhead, dark-blue Force surging around it. Jeok Cheongang thrust out a palm wreathed in pure white flames.

FWOOOOSH!

A brilliant flash enveloped everything within a radius of a dozen or so *jang*[3671]. The waves of fanatics flooding in from every direction parted.

No—they evaporated.

KWAANG! KRRRUNCH!

The ground shook with a crash that sounded as if the sky itself had split.

Bodies charred in an instant by the Flame Divine Palm's terrible heat crumpled lifelessly. Others, cut apart along with their weapons by my spear, flew away in pieces.

They had been stripped of pain and emotion, but death came equally to the hundred or so enemies who lost their lives in that moment.

And through the gap in the battlefield, blanketed in death in an instant—

Ssshh…

Four Black Ghosts rushed toward Jeok Cheongang and me, shrouded in an aura of death like dim night fog.

SHWING!

The wind split around the blades sweeping toward us with terrifying force.

Each took a direction—north, south, east, west—and struck. Their attacks meshed like finely crafted gears, leaving not the slightest opening.

But…

There is one. I'm sure of it.

I took a long step forward to meet the saber blade and spearhead streaking toward me, their outlines blurred by speed.

Straight toward those two chilling flashes aimed at my neck.

Fear of death chilled my spine, but I held fast to my conviction.

"What are you doing—!"

And just as Jeok Cheongang's urgent shout rang out—

Pshk!

The two weapons grazed either side of my neck, leaving the faintest cuts. Forgetting even that moment's pain, I smiled.

Just as I thought.

I hadn't dodged their attacks.

[3671] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

In the life-or-death moment just now, the two Black Ghosts had forced their weapons to twist and change course.

Why?

Simple.

They weren't allowed to kill me.

Their commander on this battlefield—the Blood-Sword Demon Lord—had given them that order.

The Three Elders of Tianshan couldn't have done that.

No, that wasn't right.

They wouldn't have done it.

Unlike the Black Ghosts, they still had their emotions and reason. Their own lives would have mattered a hundred, a thousand times more to them than carrying out an order.

They would have known that making even this tiny mistake to capture me would lead straight to their deaths.

Just like now.

SHWOOOSH!

I didn't miss the opening that had been invisible until they exposed it themselves.

THUD!

A Black Ghost went rigid as a statue.

White Flame's spearhead pierced its throat, and the four *jiazi*[3672] of Scorching Yang Qi I'd sent through it erupted.

KABOOOM!

Flames exploded.

Before the headless Black Ghost could fall from its saddle, another belatedly realized its comrade was in danger. It twisted the saber that had passed beside my neck and swung.

SHNK!

Hot. The force of the wind alone sliced into my shoulder, sending blood gushing from the wound.

But when you lose something, you gain something too.

KRRUNCH.

A touch so cold it sent a shiver through me.

With my free hand, I seized the wrist encased in jet-black armor and twisted it without hesitation, as though wringing it dry.

CRACK. KRRUNCH.

Flesh and bone crushed with a sickening, wet sound.

[3672] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle. Four *jiazi* represent 240 years' worth of cultivated energy.

The Black Ghosts had grown stronger through death and rebirth. I had surpassed human limits by surviving countless brushes with death.

So they weren't the only monsters here.

KRRRUNCH!

I ripped off its wrist, the weapon still gripped in its hand, and drove my fist into the Black Ghost as it stood frozen.

KWAANG!

The body went flying, trailing a foul, burnt stench as its black armor shattered.

But I knew.

I knew what kind of monsters they were, and how tenacious and dreadful the cursed life they'd been given could be.

Step.

Leaving Jeok Cheongang to fight the other two Black Ghosts, I walked toward the ones already staggering to their feet.

"Fine. Let's find out."

Ssshh…

Dusky mist rose around their bodies, regenerating the arm I'd torn away, the flesh and bone melted and crumbled by flames—even the missing neck.

"Which of us is the bigger monster?"

SHWOOOOSH—SHNK!

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

Fire blazed around the dazzling white spearhead. The strike flashed through the mist like lightning, becoming a dark-blue wave that cleaved through them.

"Magnificent. Absolutely magnificent!"

Like a child given a toy he loved on his birthday, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord watched the battlefield spread before him, his face flushed with excitement.

CLANG-CLANG-CLANG!

From the high hill to the snowy plain in the distance, a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords danced across hundreds of *jang*[3673]. Those gleaming blades, forged and tempered again and again for a single purpose, were finally doing their work.

THUD!

"AAAGH!"

Amid the shouts and screams pouring in from every direction, crimson blood sprayed over everyone's heads like a fountain.

[3673] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Dozens of lives vanished with one breath in. With one breath out, their places were filled.

Even now, death followed death without end across the horrific battlefield. It was enough to stir the nostalgia of someone who'd spent so many years confined to the lands beyond the desert.

"This is it. This is what I wanted…"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord murmured as if half in a daze. His eyes had grown hazy and moist.

How he'd missed it.

How he'd longed for it.

In the distant past, he'd led a hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path across the land at the side of the one called the Heavenly Demon. But those memories weren't especially pleasant for the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

Even then, he'd been nothing more than a hunting dog mad for blood, and the Heavenly Demon had given him little authority to command.

Now things were different.

His new master had given the Blood-Sword Demon Lord power over the lives and deaths of tens of thousands.

All he'd been given was one simple condition: under no circumstances was he to kill Jin Taekyung.

To show me such absolute trust…

The seven Black Ghosts he'd been given were proof enough.

And besides…

With them there, we cannot lose this battle. Not under any circumstances.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord looked away from the battlefield toward the white-robed figures under heavy guard not far away.

They were no less formidable than the Black Ghosts. Perhaps they would prove an even greater force.

Chapter 1034

Dressed from head to toe in white so pure it looked almost unnatural, they stood out among Dark Heaven's pitch-black ranks.

Their sleeves were so long and full they dragged on the ground. Veils hid most of their faces.

Wrapped without a gap in what looked less like clothing than great swaths of silk, they watched the battlefield in silence. Even the Blood-Sword Demon Lord was unaccustomed to the sight of them.

No—in a way, they made him uncomfortable.

Unlike the Black Ghosts—former comrades who had shared meals with him before becoming mindless killing machines—the white-robed figures answered not to him, but to "that person."

If that were all, it might have been easier to bear.

A moment ago, his eyes had been bright as he watched blood spread across the battlefield. Now displeasure flickered through them.

Such a magnificent battlefield right before me, and I have to stand here watching.

It was more than displeasure. He was beginning to feel downright offended.

His gaze swept over the twenty white-robed figures and stopped on one of them. He remembered the quiet voice that had halted him when he had eagerly moved to the front fifteen minutes earlier.

"Demon Lord, please be patient a little longer. The time is not yet ripe."

Had anyone said that to him during the Great Faction War, he would have torn open the fool's mouth and ripped out his tongue.

But fifty years was a long time. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had grown a little more mature.

More precisely, fear and reverence for his new master, the Lord of Heaven, had stayed his feet and checked his murderous impulse.

Damn it.

There was a simple reason the slender figure he was glaring at had survived daring to interfere with him.

If not for that person…

She led the white-robed figures and had served the Lord of Heaven even more closely than he had. Born killer though he was, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord could hardly use a mere slight as grounds to strike her down.

That did not mean he could swallow his irritation.

"They're holding up rather well. If I'd stepped in sooner, the battle would have swung decisively in our favor by now."

His gaze and voice made the mockery plain. Neither the figure he had singled out nor anyone around her replied.

Their silence stoked the anger he had been struggling to contain.

“Strange, isn’t it? You stepped in without a care when you shouldn’t have. Now you’re acting like you’ve swallowed your tongue.”

His snake-like pupils narrowed further, still fixed on her.

“Or does that mean you’d like to stay silent forever?”

At the sound of his low voice, the figure finally parted her lips.

“What answer do you want from me, Demon Lord?”

Her reply was calm, without a hint of a tremor. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s brow twitched.

“I command this army. I came here to carry out that person’s will.”

“I know. I was there, too.”

“And yet you, a mere woman, dare to give me orders?”

“I gave no order. I only tried to dissuade you.”

Beneath the white silk veil, her cherry-red lips moved again.

“And that is what that person wishes, too.”

“…!”

At the unexpected reply, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s face went rigid.

“What… did you say?”

“I said that is what that person wishes.”

“That person—the great Lord of Heaven—doesn’t want me to step in? What is that supposed to…”

He trailed off in disbelief. The woman gave a small shake of her head, and the pure-white veil swayed. Its embroidered pattern was beautiful, yet somehow uncanny.

“You misunderstand. That person simply wishes you to come to no harm, if possible.”

“Harm? Me, of all people?”

For a moment, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord doubted his ears.

It was an unbearably humiliating thing to hear—as a martial artist, and as a subordinate who had devoted himself wholeheartedly to serving someone.

He commanded more than thirty thousand demonic soldiers, the Three Elders of Tianshan—three hunting dogs who had admittedly outlived their usefulness—and seven Black Ghosts besides.

And that was not all.

He hadn’t yet revealed the full extent of his strength, but the Blood-Sword Demon Lord himself had reached the realm of supreme mastery, making him one of the greatest masters alive.

The enemy, by contrast, fell short in every respect: in the number of Supreme Peak masters who could turn a battle, in the quality of their soldiers, and in sheer momentum.

The scales were tipped already. They had been tipping even before the battle began, and they were still tipping now.

So why was that woman spouting such nonsense? Why cast a boulder into his heart and crack his certainty that he had his master's complete trust?

"Will you stake your life on what you just said?"

His eyes and voice had gone cold. The woman's answer barely changed.

"That person's care for you is as vast as the sea. Please, try to understand his wishes."

It was as good as an admission.

A faint smile touched the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's lips.

"That person cares for me. Yes, I should understand."

The smile on his face didn't look like a smile at all. The woman's voice turned urgent.

"As you know, four Demon Lords and Demon Empresses have already met their ends. That person needs at least one more loyal servant to carry out his great cause…"

"Enough. All you mean to say is that I shouldn't act rashly."

"…Demon Lord, that is not—"

"Enough. Hold your tongue. I understand that person's wishes perfectly well now."

He spoke evenly, but the thoughts left behind by the storm in his mind were anything but calm.

You are watching me yourself, and this is all you think I'm capable of?

Crack.

The joints of his clenched hand popped. His fist had gone white, and his nails began to dig into his skin.

I have served you with all I have. I followed you more faithfully than anyone.

He remembered the day he first met the Lord of Heaven. The trembling born of unimaginable fear and reverence, the shock that had made him think his heart might stop—he remembered it as clearly as if it had happened yesterday.

Though I was not given the post I wanted, I have lived these fifty years and more solely to serve your great cause.

The Great Faction War.

When the Heavenly Demon met his end at the Martial God's hands near the close of that long war, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had not been shaken in the slightest.

Of course he hadn't. The Heavenly Demon he had known was only human.

The ambition that had once seemed so grand, the martial might that had forced the young Blood-Sword Demon Lord to his knees—both had lost their luster after he met the Lord of Heaven.

He had felt no sorrow. He had been glad to find a master truly worthy of his service.

Glad until five other great fiends took seats above him in the newly risen Dark Heaven.

Even then, I simply obeyed you.

He'd understood without a word.

The Western Heaven Demon Lord had outranked him in the Demonic Cult, so his position was justified. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord and the North Heaven Demon Lord were daggers planted deep in the Central Plains; the importance of their roles warranted high standing.

He could understand the Southern Heaven Demon Empress and the Blood Lord as well.

Discontent had taken root in his heart, but their positions were his master's will.

But…

Now, before it's too late, you should have trusted me at least a little.

The four Demon Lords and Demon Empress the Lord of Heaven had trusted so deeply had all met their ends. They had failed their missions spectacularly, then left this world before anyone could even call them to account.

At last, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's turn had come.

Together with the Blood Lord, who had stubbornly survived, he had finally become one of the Lord of Heaven's two arms. Whether he was the right or the left hardly mattered.

His master's trust and the opportunity he had been given—that was all he had wanted.

That was all.

But what was there to worry about so much?

None of the dead Demon Lords or the Demon Empress had led an army like his. None had commanded seven Black Ghosts and tens of thousands of soldiers.

He had every condition for victory that they had lacked. Yet his master still did not trust him fully.

He could hear that distrust in the words of the woman dressed in snow-white robes.

"Did you trust me so little?"

The lament meant to remain in his heart slipped between his lips.

KWA-BOOOOM!

A pillar of fire shot skyward with a roar that seemed to split the heavens. Even from dozens of *jang*[3674] away, where the Blood-Sword Demon Lord stood, it was unmistakable. It could be seen from anywhere on the battlefield—immense, raging, and merciless.

GRRRRRR!

A violent tremor traveled through the ground.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had turned at the sudden wave of power even before the roar reached him. He took in the scene and murmured to his absent master once more.

“If you’d trusted me just a little more, this battle might already have been over.”

“Demon Lord…!”

“What? Am I not allowed even this much of a complaint?”

He answered the woman’s urgent cry without looking back. His eyes were on the haze rising in the distance—or rather, on the two figures streaking through the terrible heat that had produced it.

KRAK, BOOM!

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

Each punch and palm strike burst the murky black fog apart. As the fog gathered to repair the damage, dark-blue Force slashed through it from every direction.

SHHK—KWA-BOOOOM!

Four Black Ghosts staggered again and again. Dark energy welled from the severed ends of their limbs like blood of another color. They looked unmistakably like humans on the verge of death.

No—the Blood-Sword Demon Lord knew it instinctively.

Eternal death was finally coming for them, too.

Gooooooong.

Space suddenly began to distort. Great Force surged around the white spearhead, rising and rolling in waves.

Like…

A dragon.

And at the moment the Blood-Sword Demon Lord muttered those words to himself, the spear, now one with its master, fell toward the Black Ghosts like a bolt of lightning.

SHWAAASH!

Heavenly Strike.

[3674] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

[3675] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

The distant flash swept through a radius of dozens of *jang*[3675], bathing everything in light and shaking the ground. In its wake, nothing remained.

Not the four Black Ghosts. Not the followers who had kept charging at the master and his disciple without pause.

Only one thing remained: the resolve of a born killer determined to prove himself to his master.

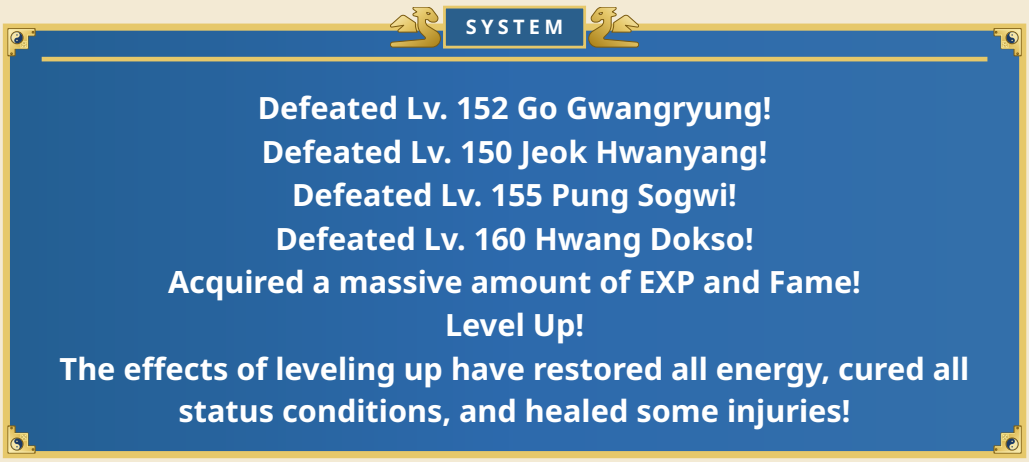
SHING.

A sharp sound brushed the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s ear.

Chapter 1035

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Clear chimes rang in my ears. At the same moment, System notifications confirmed the results of my actions, and new vitality welled up from deep within me.



Shaaah.

Was this what it felt like to wash yourself from head to toe in a cool mountain stream on a sweltering summer day?

I took a deep breath as the exhaustion of that brief but fierce fight melted away all at once.

Whew.

But it wasn't a sigh of relief at having taken down four Black Ghosts.

It was only a breath to steady myself while I waited for the one person still standing—the one we had to defeat to win this battle.

"Old Master."

"Yeah."

Jeok Cheongang nodded at my brief call.

"He's coming."

At that moment—

Clack, clack, clack.

The Dark Heaven followers had never seemed to grow fewer, no matter how many we killed. Even after the Black Ghosts fell, those fanatics had kept closing in around us. Now they stopped in unison.

Then they opened a path with grave, orderly movements.

A path for just one person.

Step. Step.

"My apologies. I'm later than I intended."

His footsteps and calm voice carried clearly, even from a distance.

I shrugged at the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

Thump.

I kicked the remains of what had been called Black Ghosts—now scattered into dozens of large and small fragments.

“If you’re sorry, go kill yourself.”

“That would be difficult.”

“Figured. Anyway, I’m fine. I was playing with your friends.”

“Friends? If you mean the trash lying there, you’re mistaken.”

“Trash?”

“Every one of them was pathetic. During the Great Faction War, they either ran wild like reckless brats who didn’t know their place and got themselves killed, or failed to recognize the true Heaven and raised their swords against it.”

That gave me an idea of what the Black Ghosts—the Death Knights who had appeared here today—had been in life.

“They were Demonic Cult fiends. You used to eat from the same pot.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord nodded readily.

“Once. A very long time ago.”

I’d suspected as much.

Everything that came into being had a cause. To make Death Knights this powerful, you obviously needed people of comparable stature to make them from.

“No wonder. Even their names sound like they belonged to a bunch of lowlife bastards.”

“Their names?”

“Go Gwangryung, Jeok Hwanyang, Pung Sogwi, Hwang Dokso… No one with a normal head comes up with names like those. Right?”

The names came out without a moment’s hesitation. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord looked at me in surprise.

“How strange. How do you know their names?”

“What, weren’t they famous? Just hearing their names puts me in a shitty mood. I can practically tell what kind of lives they led.”

“There was a time when everyone in the Central Plains knew of them. By their sobriquets, that is. But…”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord looked between Jeok Cheongang and me before adding, “A martial artist is known by their martial arts and sobriquet, not their name. Even back then, very few knew those men’s real names. Even with someone who’s spent many years gaining experience at your side, you couldn’t have learned those names.”

He sounded certain.

And for good reason. Xinjiang, once the Demonic Cult's stronghold and now Dark Heaven's home, had always been that kind of place.

A Land of Ruin where no one could set foot without permission.

A religious state beyond the desert, whose veil even the Hidden Shadow Pavilion had managed to lift only a little, after long and meticulous preparation.

But I was different.

I could read information no one else knew, even if it was only in fragments.

As long as the subject was in front of me.

And as long as the gap between our strength and abilities wasn't too great.

Shaaah!

At that moment, a blue circle I couldn't see swallowed up the space around us in a flash of light, responding to my will.

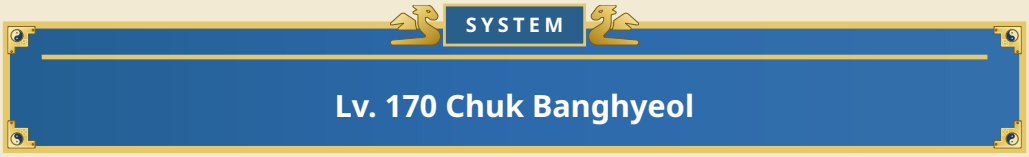
Qi Sense, now nine-tenths mastered, reached out from me and washed an area more than fifty *jang*[3676] in radius in blue.

Ding. Ding-ding-ding.

Countless System windows appeared over the heads of the hundreds—no, thousands—of enemies within Qi Sense's range.

But my gaze stayed fixed on one person.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had stopped walking the instant Qi Sense activated.



I could clearly make out the Level window above his head from more than twenty *jang*[3677] away.

I could see his furrowed brow and puzzled expression, too.

"What in the world did you just—"

Qi Sense wasn't a term exclusive to me. Martial artists who had reached a certain realm routinely gauged and read their own qi and that of others.

But Qi Sense as part of the System felt different from theirs.

"What did you do?"

His voice had dropped. The warmth had gone from his tone.

I grinned at him.

"Our Banghyeol sure has a lot of questions. Is it because you're still in your prime?"

[3676] A *jang* is ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 152 m (500 ft); twenty *jang* is about 61 m (200 ft).

[3677] A *jang* is ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Fifty *jang* is about 152 m (500 ft); twenty *jang* is about 61 m (200 ft).

"…!"

"Oh, was that name a secret too? Why do you fiends have so much to hide?"

Jeok Cheongang had experienced my Qi Sense when we first met in Shanxi Province. He clicked his tongue and joined in.

"You may not know this, but that thing feels pretty damn unpleasant. The first time, even I thought some bizarre dark art had been used on me."

"But he's a fiend. Shouldn't dark arts feel familiar to him?"

"Well…"

Jeok Cheongang studied the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's rigid face before answering.

"Maybe he's embarrassed. Even from what little I've heard, it's not a very good name. Banghyeol? That's supposed to be a person's name? Sounds like a fart."

"Come on. Even if you're old enough to have shoved your years up your ass, you can't make fun of him for that. That man's probably almost a hundred himself."

"You wait till you're old. Sometimes you feel strange for no reason. Who knows? Maybe he sits under the moon every night with tears in his eyes."

"Oh."

The idea that a notorious great fiend had finally entered menopause was pretty interesting. But the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's next words wiped the look from my face.

"You're right, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung."

"What?"

"Didn't you just say it yourself? That dark arts ought to be familiar to him."

He gazed down at his hands, as though trying to recall the sensation my Qi Sense had left behind.

"I see. It's a little different from what I know, but it does feel familiar."

"…!"

My eyes widened before I could stop them.

Different, but familiar.

The meaning of those few words was becoming clearer. So was the source of the unease rising within me.

"At first, I was surprised. Now I finally understand why that person watched you so closely."

Step. Step. Splash.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord crossed the dry, frozen ground and stepped into a pool of blood.

Plip.

Blood splashed with his roughened stride.

A powerful energy covered the slowly rising blade, thicker and more viscous than the blood itself.

“But this time, that person was wrong. I should have handled this myself from the start. There was never any need to stop me or worry about me.”

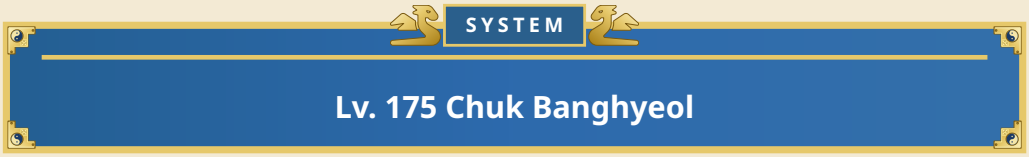
Wooooong.

I felt something change around the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

Not because the wind had stopped and the air was trembling.

Not because the sword in his grip was roaring as it poured out immense Force.

Beep.



“...!”

It had changed.

The qi he gave off. The number in his Level window.

This is...

I knew instinctively.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord hadn’t simply been concealing his strength through Returning to Simplicity.

He definitely, definitely wasn’t this strong before.

We had clashed once before the battle began in earnest. Jeok Cheongang and I had fought at full strength, and so had the Blood-Sword Demon Lord. The result had been clear: he was at a disadvantage.

So why?

Beep.

How?

Beep.

How was the Blood-Sword Demon Lord growing stronger even now, as he slowly approached us?

“What in the world… What dark art are you using?”

There was no way a master wouldn’t feel what his Disciple felt.

Jeok Cheongang’s question cast light on the unease that had been swelling inside me.

Dark arts.

A dark, devious technique, just as the words themselves meant.

Those who used them had strayed from the straight and righteous path into demonic, heterodox arts. And those who dwelled deepest in that abyss belonged to what people called—

The Demonic Path.

People who rejected life as humans and chose the path of demons.

Then what should the dark arts wielded by beings so full of incomprehensible mysteries be called?

How had those beings known as Black Ghosts come into existence, and appeared here?

“…No.”

“What?”

“It’s not dark arts.”

The words slipped from my lips in a dazed murmur.

Jeok Cheongang’s repeated questions grew distant, like echoes. For a moment, I even forgot the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s presence, growing stronger with every step he took toward us.

As if entranced, I looked at the white-robed figures.

Until now, his presence had obscured them. They were only a tiny part of this vast battlefield, where the fighting still raged.

No. Like the Black Ghosts, they possessed power that should not exist in this world.

“Magic.”

And the moment that familiar, unbelievable word slipped from my lips—

“Power of the Wind Ghost.”

A chant rang out clearly from far away.

“Dwell within him.”

The spell, imbued with intent, manifested in the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s body.

Chapter 1036

Had I failed to guess it from the start? Or had I tried to deny it because the truth was so hard to believe?

This time, I could answer that question myself.

I think it was the latter.

It was true. All of it.

The realization struck my mind, leaving it blank as a sheet of paper.

At the same time, I felt the last shred of faith I'd held on to crumble, along with everything I'd thought I knew about this world.

The strange Moving Formation, whose existence had already been revealed long ago in Henan and Sichuan.

The Water God Dragon and countless Blood Fish, corrupted by something in Hubei and driven into a frenzy.

An utterly ordinary fisherman who'd eaten those Blood Fish and gained a monster's appearance and strength.

The cause of all those phenomena—and not just that, but the rift that had appeared once more in the jungles of Nanman.

Even the familiar beings called Black Ghosts, whom I'd faced right here today.

And.

And…

At last, it was unmistakable.

It was unfolding right before my eyes. I could hear it, feel it flowing clearly through my senses.

All the warnings that had come before—call them signs, omens, whatever you wanted.

They had finally broken through a great dam and come crashing down on me, turning the suspicion I'd only entertained in private into certainty.

In two characters:

Magic.

Shaaah.

The wind blew. A shadow moving with speed and power far beyond human limits glided toward me, trailing a long afterimage.

But I couldn't even twitch a finger.

In a world gone slow, with my whole body feeling as if the blood in it had turned cold, all I could do was stare, dumbfounded.

What is this…?

Where a massive bomb had exploded, nothing remained but ruins and the shock wave.

My mind was wreckage now. Words and questions scattered through it, caught in the blast.

Magic. Mage. Monster. Blood-Sword Demon Lord. Buff.

A large-scale attack spell. Allies sacrificed. Countless deaths, blood spilling everywhere, broken bodies floating in it.

How was any of this possible?

How had it come to this?

And finally—

What am I supposed to do now?

Every thought scattered. Only that question remained, and I had no answer.

Grab.

A hard, rough hand—one I knew—closed around my shoulder.

No. The instant I felt it, a powerful force had already dragged me backward, sending me stumbling without strength.

Only then did time begin to move again. A streak of light was swung through the gap like lightning.

Whoooom—KABOOM!

A roar like the sky splitting apart brought my senses rushing back.

I was already airborne somewhere behind where I'd stood. As I hung weightless, an enormous shock wave struck.

KRRRACK!

The ground heaved like an earthquake had hit. Two immense forces melted and shattered everything around them.

At the center of the clash, which swallowed dozens of *jang*[3678] in every direction, stood Jeok Cheongang. He had shoved me aside when I froze like a statue and stepped in to stop the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

"Hah!"

How had I flown so far already?

Even at this distance, I could tell Jeok Cheongang's shout, charged with profound internal energy, was more than a battle cry.

That was for me. He's trying to wake me up.

It reached my ears and jolted my half-dazed mind awake. At last, I let out the breath I'd been holding.

Right. It's not over yet.

[3678] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

I still couldn't understand how any of this could be happening. But with death right in front of me, what did understanding matter?

There was no use in understanding when the water had already spilled.

All I could do on this battlefield was accept what was happening and find a way through it.

That was how I'd save everyone.

Srrk.

Still suspended in the air, I twisted smoothly around.

My muscles and internal energy, fully restored by that last Level Up, obeyed the command in my mind without the slightest delay or error.

Now.

Boom—shwaaash!

I kicked off the air with a foot charged with qi and shot toward Jeok Cheongang, who was clashing with the Blood-Sword Demon Lord more than twenty *jang*[3679] away.

Or I tried to.

As I cut through the wind, an immense, invisible force descended on me.

Wooooong.

The air vanished. The wind vanished.

The instant I noticed, I heard a faint voice from far away.

"Taishan."

"…!"

I knew what that quiet invocation meant. My eyes widened, but I couldn't stop the clear voice issuing from beneath a pure-white veil on a hill fifty *jang*[3680] away.

"Bring him down. Crush him."

At that very moment—

Fwooom!

A weight as immense as Taishan bore down on my whole body.

No—it sent me plummeting.

Straight toward the countless enemies who had gathered like clouds during the brief moment I'd been airborne, their spears and bows aimed at me.

Gravity magic…!

I swallowed my cry of shock.

Instead of resisting this second, unexpected spell, I let it take hold and turned it into a weapon.

KWA-BOOM!

[3679] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3680] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

I struck the ground under the weight of ten thousand *geun*.[3681] The earth split, and the enemies around me staggered off balance. At the same time, I felt the pressure pinning me down dissipate.

Of course.

Gravity acted on an area, not a single person.

While I was airborne, I'd been the first to feel the spell's effects. Once I landed, that was no longer true.

The white-robed figures were clearly mages. If they wanted to bind me even a little, their gravity magic would have to target the Dark Heaven followers who were their allies, too.

So they meant to delay me from joining Jeok Cheongang, even if only this way…

Fine by me.

The followers staggered like soulless wooden puppets. I turned in place and swept White Flame across them.

KWA-AAAH!

The spear's passage through the air sounded more than fierce—outright destructive.

Anyone could swing a spear sideways. But none of the enemies surrounding me could stop the wave of Force that burst from White Flame's translucent spearhead.

Not one.

SHHK! KRRRACK!

Everything was cut apart and crushed.

Weapons. People.

In the blink of an eye, the ground within a three-*jang*[3682] radius had become a field of death. Yet the fear had been stripped from them. They stared at me with dark, unseeing eyes and kept charging.

They murmured the eight-character creed as if entranced.

"Heaven above, earth below."

"All demons bow."

"Heaven above…"

CRUNCH!

A headless body toppled. My spear flashed sideways through three more enemies closing in from the flank.

SHK!

Weapons imbued with Sword Energy and bodies hardened by the external arts alike were helpless against overwhelming force.

[3681] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is about 6,000 kg (13,200 lb).

[3682] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

I drove through the scattering fragments of steel and flesh without hesitation.

I streaked like lightning between the enemies blocking my way like a wall, thinking and commanding without pause.

Open Inventory. Summon. Summon. Summon.

SHHK, THUNK, KRRRACK!

I cut, stabbed, and crushed my way forward.

Weapons stayed in my hands only briefly. Each took one life, or two or three, before it left me. Countless more blades still lay hidden in that vast subspace whose limits I couldn't begin to guess.

For a moment, the thought crossed my mind that perhaps I could make some ridiculous idea real.

No. There's no way.

But why?

CLANG!

I knocked aside the weapons coming at me from every direction.

THWACK!

I crushed the head of an enemy approaching from my blind spot with a single punch.

SHWEEESH—SHHK!

And the more enemies I cut down, the stronger that inexplicable certainty grew.

Could this really be nothing more than a fantasy?

SHWAAASH!

I turned and swung my spear, leaving a mist of blood along its path.

As enemies surged in from every direction to fill the gap left by the dead, I took a short breath.

I won't know until I try.

Thinking back, it had always been like this.

Every time I needed to break through a wall, I had to go beyond it. I had to make the impossible possible, turn imagination into reality.

Just as I would now.

Open Inventory.

One breath. That was all the time I needed.

With countless enemies still blocking my path, filling every space no matter how many I killed, I quietly closed my eyes. I pictured the mountain of sharp, gleaming steel somewhere in the void called the Inventory.

Then I gave the command.

Summon.

It was madness. The sort of thing that could exist only in my imagination.

But the System answered that absurd, desperate call.

The way it always did.

Ding.

One small, clear chime.

Ding. Ding. Ding-ding.

Chimes layered over one another. Their faint ripples grew into a wave that swallowed the space around me.

Ding-ding-ding-ding-ding!

My ears grew muffled. This was the first step toward making imagination real.

I opened my eyes to a chime vaster and more majestic than any I'd ever heard.

And saw it.

Shaaah.

Something had forced its way through a gap in unseen space above my head, casting a shadow below.

I heard it, too.

Shrring.

The cold sound of hundreds of pieces of steel sliding against one another.

And finally—

I can do this.

I felt it. I understood.

What I was capable of, the limits I had been given, stretched far beyond anything I'd imagined.

I had the power to make at least part of that ridiculous idea real.

Fwoosh.

In the slowed world, immense qi surged from deep within me.

The fire dragon coiled in my lower dantian flowed through every limb and bone. Blood rushed with the pounding of my heart.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

A fierce tremor. A racing pulse.

No. That's not it.

The beat wasn't coming from my heart alone.

The Jade Hall Acupoint.

What the people called martial artists had newly named the Middle Dantian.

Every nerve, every sense I possessed was fixed there.

Past the lower dantian, where lava surged in waves, to that lofty peak rising toward the heavens.

To a realm of Will that strength and speed could not measure.

Kiiiiing.

My vision blurred. Agony stabbed through my head as though someone were driving a needle into it.

But I spread my arms as if entranced.

A flash filled my sight, and I felt a thrill greater than the pain. My hands were empty, yet somewhere beyond the reach of touch, I felt and grasped each thing, one by one.

One, two, three.

Ten, twenty, thirty.

And at last…

One hundred.

I opened my eyes.

In that time that had felt like eternity, yet lasted no more than an instant.

Beneath a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords—a hundred blades aimed at countless enemies as if held by an invisible hand.

I parted my tightly closed lips.

“Move.”

SHWAAAAASH!

The sky filled with flashes of light.

Chapter 1037

Sama Pyo suddenly wondered where he was, who he was, and what he was supposed to do against the enemies still pouring in.

Thwack!

Even as the thought crossed his mind, his saber moved on instinct and cut through an enemy's neck. But Sama Pyo already knew: even if he cut down dozens, hundreds, tens of thousands more would remain.

His strength was far too meager to turn the tide of this disadvantageous battle.

Clang! Krrr-crack!

"Argh!"

"Gah…!"

Horrifying screams rang out from every direction.

No—more precisely, only their allies were screaming.

At the center of the front line, which was crumbling beneath an endless spray of blood, Sama Pyo could see what was coming.

At this rate… it's all over.

His body was exhausted, but his mind was colder than ever. His judgment was clear.

When two forces of roughly equal size clashed, the quality of their troops and their momentum decided the outcome. And Dark Heaven's army had them beaten on both counts.

Half an hour at most. No—fifteen minutes. The front line will collapse by then.

He kept to himself the thought that would have plunged any of his allies into despair and charged at another enemy.

Jin Taekyung had plunged so deep into the enemy ranks that Sama Pyo could no longer see him. Sama Pyo could barely hold the line, let alone follow. Anger at his own helplessness drove his next strike.

Slice!

One clean strike cleaved the enemy's upper body in two.

Beneath the shower of blood, a young martial artist who had been trembling in the certainty of his own death lit up with relief.

"Th-thank you… Huh?"

His eyes widened. He sounded dazed.

He looked barely twenty. Just as he recognized Sama Pyo, Sama Pyo recognized the Black Dragon Demon Gate uniform he wore. Something about him seemed familiar, too.

Where have I seen him before?

But the question only flickered through his mind. A moment later, Sama Pyo hurriedly twisted around and swung his saber.

Whish—Kkakak!

Sword Energy tore through the air and met his blade with a violent screech.

Beyond their locked weapons, his opponent's eyes were vacant as a corpse's. The Sword Energy, though, shone fiercely—brighter and sharper than Sama Pyo's own.

A master...!

One brief clash was enough to feel the gap between them down to his bones.

But there was one thing Sama Pyo had failed to notice.

Crack.

His saber had been battered and dulled in clashes with dozens of enemies. It was too weak to withstand the fierce Sword Energy of a man who stood at the threshold of the Peak realm.

KWA-CLANG!

The clash ended almost as soon as it began.

Half of Sama Pyo's blade spun high into the air. A streak of light shot straight toward him.

Danger!

An alarm blared in his mind at the sight of that devastating flash. Instinct spoke before reason could.

Dodge. Survive, whatever it takes. No matter how disgraceful it looks.

But...

Where am I supposed to dodge?

Time seemed to slow, as though his life were flashing before his eyes. Sama Pyo was acutely aware of everything around him.

Clang-clang! Thud!

"Gaaah!"

The ceaseless clash of blades. Blood scattering through the air. Dying screams.

And his allies, still facing the enemy in a line so tightly packed their shoulders brushed.

Sama Pyo could clearly sense the tremor in their breathing. And at the same time, he knew:

There's nowhere to dodge.

No. That wasn't true.

He could dart to either side right now, or duck and roll to avoid as much of the enemy's Sword Energy as possible.

Narye tagon?[3683]

[3683] *Narye tagon* is an idiom likening an evasive roll to a lazy donkey rolling on the ground; it implies humiliation.

Who cared? Dignity was a luxury in the face of death.

Covered in filth instead of blood, or with an ally used as his shield—it made no difference. Surviving by any means necessary was the way of the unorthodox faction.

That was what his father, the Black Night King Sima Gong, had taught him—the man who'd passed his blood down to him.

Yes. That's what he taught me.

But things had changed.

One year.

In that short time, the son had stepped out from beneath the shadow his father had cast over his entire life. He had met people, lived through much, and changed.

That was why Sama Pyo saw no way out now.

He could dodge. He couldn't dodge.

If he avoided the Sword Energy creeping toward him through that seemingly frozen moment, one of his allies would surely die.

What a damn mess.

The curse rested soundlessly on the tip of his tongue.

Sama Pyo didn't notice the faint smile forming on his lips. Nor did he notice how strangely relieved he felt, even with death right before his eyes.

He launched the dagger he'd hidden under his sleeve, thinking that if the person who'd suddenly come to mind were watching, they might even praise him for this.

Not a bad end for an unorthodox bastard, don't you think, Pavilion Master?

Sama Pyo smiled brightly.

At the same time, he felt the enemy's Sword Energy grow even fiercer. It swallowed the dagger flying toward it and surged toward his chest.

Then he heard two sharp, unexpected whistles through the air.

Slice! Thud!

Sama Pyo stared with wide eyes.

At the last moment, someone had leaped in front of him. Blood sprayed from the man's chest as he staggered. Over his shoulder, a blackish-blue saber blade drove through the enemy's throat.

This is…

Sama Pyo recognized the blade at once. It was the Black Dragon Saber, his treasured weapon, which he had left behind before the meeting with the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

He recognized the owner of the Force imbued in it, too.

"You fool."

That chilling voice was utterly familiar—and one he could never grow used to.

Thwack!

The twisted blade of the Black Dragon Saber finished severing the enemy's neck. Black Force rose like a spreading wildfire and swept across the front.

KRRR-CRACK!

A fierce, blood-red gale engulfed dozens of enemies. The allies who witnessed that overwhelming display of martial might cried out one after another.

"S-Sect Leader!"

"The Sect Leader is here!"

The Black Night King, Sima Gong, had finally appeared on the front line. The great tree that supported the unorthodox Murim had come with the finest martial artists of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

"Attack."

A single word escaped his tightly pressed lips.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh! KABOOM!

Dozens of Peak masters plunged into the enemy ranks.

Cheers broke out across the front. For that moment, none of the allies holding it dared ask why Sima Gong had only appeared now, or why he had stayed in the rear when he'd had plenty of time to join them.

None but one.

"You're late."

The son did not look at the father he had met on the battlefield.

Sama Pyo was looking at the body of the young martial artist who had just thrown himself in front of him. The boy he had saved a moment earlier had looked as though the peach fuzz had scarcely left his face.

His father followed his gaze to the body. His reply was cold.

"He died because you were weak."

"That's right. If I'd been stronger, he would've lived."

Sama Pyo nodded calmly, then spoke without restraint.

"Then what were you doing, when you're so strong?"

"What?"

"The monsters called Black Ghosts never came this way. If you'd brought your forces in at the right time, we could have broken through the enemy lines."

Why hadn't the Black Ghosts appeared here? Sima Gong commanded thirty thousand troops, a force central to this battle. Why hadn't the enemy targeted it?

And why had his father stood by while that opportunity passed?

Sima Gong's gaze darkened as his son voiced the questions everyone else had momentarily forgotten.

What are you trying to say?

At the sudden Sound Transmission in his ear, Sama Pyo gave a quiet laugh.

Why? Afraid someone might hear?

How dare you…

I'd already suspected you had other plans. But I kept telling myself it couldn't be true. I wanted to believe in you.

His son—no, Sama Pyo—drew a deep breath.

You're still my father, after all.

…!

Do you still not understand why I volunteered for a position that was practically a death sentence?

Sama Pyo had known instinctively that his father was harboring other intentions. He had known that if the heir to everything Sima Gong had built over his lifetime had not been in danger, his father would not have appeared here even now.

"But please, don't worry. However this battle ends, the Black Dragon Demon Gate will survive."

For the first time, the son chose a path different from his father's. He turned away without hesitation. Before charging back toward the enemy, he offered one more remark—perhaps the last he would ever make to him.

"It looks like the other one is dead already. A pity."

The son left those cryptic words behind. The father remained.

When Sima Gong's gaze, still frozen like a statue, finally settled on the fallen body, he suddenly remembered a middle-aged man and a young man from several days earlier, as they crossed the desert. They'd dared to speak of the Black Dragon Demon Gate's and Sama Pyo's hidden history.

And the command he'd given that had decided their fate in an instant.

See to it as you see fit.

The order had been carried out. Both men had been placed in the most dangerous part of the front line, and both had died.

But the Black Night King, Sima Gong, had not known.

No one could have known that a young man whom a cold-hearted father had sent to his death would save his son.

"…What a cruel twist of fate."

Sima Gong murmured quietly, then looked down at the Black Dragon Saber in his hand.

The treasured blade he had given his son as his first and last gift now reflected an old man with a troubled look in his eyes.

At that moment, it caught a distant flash of light as well.

It was like lightning.

Bolt after bolt falling without pause, tearing and burning everything beneath them with overwhelming force.

Yet everyone staring wide-eyed at the distant scene knew what they were seeing. Their heightened senses, their instincts and common sense as martial artists, told them what those countless flashes lighting up the battlefield really were.

They were blades, like the ones in their own hands.

Fwoosh!

Dozens of brilliant streaks tore through the darkness beneath the heavy clouds.

They moved freely through the air, like living things, sweeping over beings that could no longer be called alive because they felt nothing.

KRRR-CRACK!

No screams followed—only the sickening sound of flesh being torn apart.

Weapons forged through hundreds of rounds of tempering in lands beyond the desert shattered the moment they met that wave of steel. Their wielders fared no better.

Splash. Thud-thud-thud!

Blood surged up like a wave.

Beneath that red rain, bursting from the bodies of dozens and soaking the ground, one man slowly walked forward.

Squish.

Sticky. Blood pooled up to his ankles and sloshed with each step. Its foul stench seeped into his nose.

Jin Taekyung was covered in blood from head to toe, but he kept walking.

The enormous wave of steel moved with him, subject to his Will alone.

Clack. Thud-thud-thunk!

Something clicked into place, followed by a whistle through the air. Jin Taekyung's fingers moved ever so slightly.

Clang!

Five great sabers floating through the air spread their broad blades across his flank. The steel shield opened like petals in full bloom, catching the arrowheads that came flying at him in quick succession.

It all happened in the blink of an eye.

Kakakakclang!

A dozen arrows bounced away in showers of sparks.

Jin Taekyung did not flinch. He had already made everything within a three-*jang*[3684] radius his own.

[3684] Three Korean *jang* are about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

And whoever had hidden among his allies to fire the repeating crossbow would not get another chance to ambush him.

Go.

There was no need to turn and find the archer. At Jin Taekyung's command, the five great sabers that had shielded him shot away like enormous arrows.

Thud-thud-thud!

More than twenty people died in the time it took him to exhale: the one who had fired the crossbow, those who stood in the sabers' path, and the enemies beside them.

But the five sabers didn't return, either.

Even Jin Taekyung had limits when it came to hurling steel weighing dozens of *geun*[3685] apiece like bolts of lightning.

Grit.

A terrible headache struck without warning. He clenched his teeth.

Was that too ambitious?

Unlike the Lower Dantian, the Middle Dantian was the domain of Will—of mental strength.

Controlling this many weapons was nothing short of a miracle. Imbuing each one with internal energy and controlling it perfectly was another matter.

A master of a certain level could stop weapons propelled by strength and speed alone.

Just as some of them were doing now.

Thud! Kakakakclang!

The weapons shot forward again at his command, piercing flesh and bone. But over a distance of barely ten *jang*[3686], the blades that had once numbered close to a hundred had dwindled by half. Some of the enemies who had reached the Peak realm were beginning to knock them aside without much trouble.

Not yet. Not yet.

Since the battle began, he had cut down hundreds of enemies on his own.

No—perhaps more than a thousand.

It was a feat worthy of the name One Against a Thousand.

But…

It's not enough.

The deeper he pushed into the enemy ranks, the closer he came to Jeok Cheongang's fight with the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, the stronger the enemies grew.

[3685] One Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb).

[3686] Ten Korean *jang* are about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

To bring down every enemy still surging toward him, Jin Taekyung would have to unleash everything he had.

Just one. One strike is enough.

The instant the thought arose in his mind and took shape as Will—

Slip. Clang-clang-clang!

The dozens of weapons surrounding him fell from the air.

All but one spear. It had drunk more blood than any of the other blades, yet its gleam had not faded.

Now.

Fwoosh.

In the wavering space, White Flame blazed with Force and shot forward.

At the end of its fierce passage through a human wave numbering in the hundreds stood one man.

KWA-BOOM!

A roar split the air like the sky breaking open. The immense force behind the spearhead drove a figure backward.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had been rushing at Jeok Cheongang, who was now drenched in blood. He bared his bloodstained teeth at Jin Taekyung, standing on a red path strewn with finely chopped flesh.

“So, you’ve come?”

Chapter 1038

It was probably the power of the Middle Dantian. I'd pushed it beyond its limits.

Step.

The dead and the living—everything else seemed to vanish as I stepped onto the blood-red path. At that moment, an agonizing headache unlike anything I'd ever felt before struck me.

Hup.

It felt as if a long, sharp needle were digging around inside my skull.

I held back a groan and fought to still my trembling body. If I showed the slightest weakness in front of a beast that had already bared its fangs, it would devour me on the spot.

"So, you've come?"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

The moment I heard his utterly unruffled voice, my headache doubled.

No. Maybe the real reason was the sight of Jeok Cheongang, now drenched in blood.

Or perhaps…

> **System Lv. ??? Chuk Banghyeol**

> **Lv. ??? Chuk Banghyeol**

Perhaps it was the strength of the Blood-Sword Demon Lord: a true monster whose Level I could no longer measure, even now.

At least twenty Levels above me… This is going to be an even harder fight.

Swallowing a groan, I reached out. White Flame, connected to me by an invisible thread, shot back into my grasp.

Nothing stopped it. I'd been braced for interference, but none came.

"Qi-Controlled Sword. No, should I call it Qi-Controlled Spear? You must've been in quite a hurry to push yourself this far."

He sounded as relaxed as he looked. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord smiled with the ease of a man who knew he was stronger.

"Still, I'll give you credit. Good try. At least you made it back before your master died."

He laughed and casually waved a hand. The instant he did, Jeok Cheongang spotted an opening and thrust out his palm like lightning.

"You bastard!"

KWA-AAAH!

Heat surged forward with his shout.

The force of Flame Divine Palm burned everything in its path as it bore down on the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's face. His smile never wavered.

A streak of blood-red Sword Force cut through the space between them.

SHWAK! KWA-BOOM!

The palm force split cleanly in two. Both halves flew off to either side and slammed into the ground.

A roar engulfed a dozen-*jang*[3687] radius. Acrid smoke billowed up, and through it the Blood-Sword Demon Lord appeared like a ghost and brought his sword down.

SHWAAASH!

Space warped under the terrible pressure.

But Jeok Cheongang threw himself aside as though he'd anticipated the strike, powerful enough to cleave a mountain.

SHK!

The ground split like tofu.

Jeok Cheongang narrowly avoided the blow and immediately found his footing. But the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's blurred figure was already moving toward his flank.

Danger...!

He was so fast that even I reacted too late. There was no time to shout.

In less than a breath, the two superhumans exchanged attacks like flashes of light. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord moved faster than sound.

WHOOOM—PAM!

Compressed air burst apart.

They were too close for him to swing his sword. Instead, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord struck Jeok Cheongang's shoulder with his palm, sending him flying backward like a cannonball.

And directly in his path—

SHWEEEE—THUD!

—I was racing toward him with all my strength.

"Old Master!"

The shout burst out before I knew it. With my help, Jeok Cheongang managed to stop himself. His reply came in a rasp.

"I'm fine. Stop making a fuss and lower your voice. You'll burst my eardrums."

He sounded as gruff as ever. Most people wouldn't have heard a difference, but I knew the Fire King Jeok Cheongang better than anyone.

[3687] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The greater the danger, the more he pretended to be calm. Even if it was only to reassure someone else.

“You’re doing it again. Time for your medicine.”

I sighed, placed a hand on his back, and poured internal energy into him without hesitation.

Tap. Fwoosh.

Fire joined with fire.

The Scorching Yang Qi born of the same source connected in an instant, driving out the impurities pooled deep inside his body.

“Cough.”

Drip-drip.

A mouthful of blood spilled from his lips against his will. It was black, a sign of considerable Internal Injury.

I clicked my tongue. “You’re fine, are you?”

Jeok Cheongang spat out bloody phlegm.

“It’s one mouthful of blood. What’s all the fuss?”

Honestly, I wanted to let it go. But when someone’s life was on the line, it mattered whether they were telling the truth.

THWACK!

The earlier strike had thinned the enemy forces behind us, but plenty remained. As one of them, unable to wait any longer, charged us, I kicked him in the chest and caved it in.

“You do know you’re covered head to toe in blood, right?”

“It isn’t mine. I’ve been running around so much, I got some on me.”

“That guy looks perfectly fine.”

I pointed to the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, strolling toward us through the parting waves of men. Jeok Cheongang smacked his lips.

“He must’ve been less busy.”

“Ah. Less busy. I see.”

“Anyway, I’m fine. Not a scratch on me… Well, that’s not quite true, but this much won’t stop me.”

PAM!

Jeok Cheongang sprang upright, turning three enemies to charcoal as he rose. Then he licked the blood from the corner of his mouth.

“Well?”

“Just tell me the truth. I won’t tell anyone else.”

“You insolent brat. Are you saying this old man is bluffing?”

“Aren’t you?”

“No. What’s a bastard like him to me?”

“Then I’ll go help the others.”

“Hm?”

“You can handle a bastard like him by yourself, right? Everyone else is fighting for their lives.”

Grab!

The instant I started to turn away, Jeok Cheongang snatched my wrist like lightning and replied in a stern voice.

“The wise men of old said even a sheet of paper is easier to lift when two people carry it.”

“…”

“I don’t know what trick he’s using, but every so often he gets startlingly stronger and faster. You’d think he was possessed.”

“…”

“And that’s not all. Whenever this old man tried to land a blow with all my strength, some unknown force kept stopping me. It was—”

“Old Master.”

I cut him off and added quietly, “You’re talking too much.”

“…”

“One sentence. Short and clear.”

Jeok Cheongang was silent for a moment. Then he answered exactly as I’d asked.

“That bastard’s strong as fuck.”

“Perfectly put.”

“And those pure-white things way over there are helping him with some bizarre dark arts. Every time that strange energy of theirs surges, he gets stronger. I tried to take them out before things got even worse, even if I had to overextend myself, but…”

“You failed. You got hit by those dark arts, too.”

“That’s right. What I felt then was like…”

“The sky was crushing you.”

Gravity magic. No doubt about it.

Jeok Cheongang stared at me, momentarily stunned that I’d described it so precisely. I continued calmly.

“More precisely, that’s not ordinary dark arts. It’s an ability called Magic.”

“Wait. If you mean Magic…”

“Yes. The Magic you know about. The kind you’d only see in my homeland.”

“…!”

Of course Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened. I hadn't told him every detail, but he knew something of where I came from and what kind of world it was.

Even so, he couldn't fully understand or accept what was happening. Neither could I.

But that mattered less than defeating the enemy in front of us.

We have to target them first. Not the Blood-Sword Demon Lord—those people in white. The mages.

Even as I sent him the message through Sound Transmission, a chill ran down my spine at how unfamiliar the idea felt.

Mages. Here, of all places. Not in the modern world, but in Murim.

Then I looked past the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who was still closing the distance at a leisurely stroll. On the hill behind him stood the mages, their white robes fluttering. The reality of it sank in.

We have to take them out first, no matter what.

From the moment I'd realized they were mages, I hadn't considered any other option.

I knew what the word *Magic* could mean—how many dangers and unknowns came with it. Of the tens of thousands of allies standing or falling on this battlefield, I was the only one who knew what mages could do in a battle this large.

Besides…

One of them is especially skilled. Skilled enough to hold back both me and Old Master with Magic.

Magic worked differently, but qi was still the raw material behind it. To Jeok Cheongang or me, even a fairly advanced mage wouldn't pose much of a threat.

Unless they were among the rare few said to have reached the very edge of truth.

"…A Grand Mage."

The title escaped my lips like a groan.

But just as I was about to conclude that one of them had to be a Grand Mage, a question occurred to me.

If they really have a Grand Mage, how has the battle stayed like this?

I didn't mean we were winning. Everyone, myself included, was giving it their all, and the battle was still going badly for our side.

But if the Grand Mage had stepped in, we wouldn't even have been able to keep things at this disadvantage.

I knew better than anyone what a Grand Mage could do on a battlefield. It took no thought at all to picture a wide-area attack spell unlike anything anyone in this world had ever seen.

How long could our army last against that incomprehensible power, a natural disaster with a will of its own? More than a third of our forces were an undisciplined rabble.

Yet the Grand Mage hadn't joined the fight. He had briefly hindered Jeok Cheongang and me with gravity magic and strengthened the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's body with magic, but had done nothing beyond that.

Squish.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord crossed the blood-red path. At last, he stopped.

"What exactly… are you after?"

I was genuinely curious. And uneasy.

Were the mages holding back because they were preparing a spell powerful enough to end the battle in an instant? Or were they plotting something else?

I'd blurted the question out before I could stop myself. Three *jang*[3688] away, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord watched us with a smile, then furrowed his brow.

"After? From the start, I've only wanted two things from this battle. Victory. And you."

"That's a long way of saying you won't answer."

"I don't know what you're talking about, but… it doesn't matter."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord shrugged with an expression that could have been sincere or an act, then raised the sword he'd been holding loosely and continued.

"Let's finish this. Of course, I'd prefer an ending where one of you dies and the other is taken prisoner."

Jeok Cheongang and I answered in one voice.

"Go fuck yourself."

And at that moment—

PAPAT!

We charged at the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

No. Only Jeok Cheongang shot toward him.

Hold him off for half a quarter-hour. Just half a quarter-hour.

With that Sound Transmission sent through the wind, I twisted my body and charged toward the hill.

SHWEEEE!

[3688] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 1039

It happened in the blink of an eye.

Tap—SHWEEEE!

Jin Taekyung had been hurtling straight ahead. With a slight twist of his foot, he slipped sideways, his movement flowing as though he'd been waiting for this exact moment.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord could only stare in surprise.

What the…!

He hadn't seen this coming. No one would have. With the gap between them already clear and the situation so dangerous, what Disciple would leave his injured Master behind?

But something else startled the Blood-Sword Demon Lord even more.

He's… going after the mages!

There was no doubt. Jin Taekyung veered around his flank and shot forward again, heading straight for the twenty or so white-robed figures surveying the battlefield from the foot of a high hill.

Why in the world would he—no, how could he…?

Thoughts tangled together in his mind in that fleeting instant. But now that he'd been caught off guard, there was no time to hesitate. He pushed aside every question, twisted with all his might, and thrust out a hand.

SHWAAK!

The strike tore through the air at a terrifying speed. In that instant, as time seemed to slow, the blood-red Force coiling around his blade was about to shoot toward Jin Taekyung's back.

No—in the very instant it was about to shoot forward—

FWOOSH!

That dreadful heat suddenly rushed in. In the disarray of his composure, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord remembered someone he'd momentarily forgotten.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

That son of a bitch…!

He didn't even have time to shout. The horrified Blood-Sword Demon Lord barely managed to turn his sword and block the flames that had rushed right up to him.

KWA-BOOM! GRRRR!

The ground buckled as though an earthquake had struck. Acrid black smoke and steam billowed up, blanketing the area. Through them, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord saw a fist streaming blinding white light-flames.

CRUNCH.

He saw the man behind it, too, steadily driving back his sword despite the blood-red Force wrapped around it.

"You dare take your eyes off me?"

Beyond the trembling blade, barely holding back the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared at Jeok Cheongang's faint smile. His gaze sank low.

It was too late. One moment of surprise, one moment of carelessness, and Jin Taekyung had slipped away.

"You've still got plenty of energy, Senior. At your age, shouldn't you be resting in a coffin?"

"Under normal circumstances, perhaps. But one day, someone high above the clouds told me something."

FWOOSH.

The flames rose even more fiercely, belying the Internal Injury Jeok Cheongang had suffered earlier. He breathed out a scorching sigh.

"He said he'd send me a wild little brat for a Disciple—an extraordinary one—and that I should build coffins for other bastards until the boy learned to act like an adult."

"…!"

"But what use would this old man have for coffins? I can burn the whole lot of you to ashes. Wouldn't you agree?"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord's sword was still being pushed back. It wasn't simply because Jeok Cheongang had drawn on every last bit of strength he had.

It was his aura.

The history behind the name Fire King. The weight of the years borne by an old giant who had lived for more than a century.

And…

"Even if you died and came back a hundred times, you'd never understand why I'm here."

It was the spirit only shown by those who fought with their lives on the line—not to kill someone, but to protect something precious.

"So when you die this time, don't be reborn as a human again."

Ghostly blue fire, like the flames of hell, flickered in Jeok Cheongang's eyes.

For an instant, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord felt overwhelmed. He clenched his teeth.

"This damned old monster dares to…!"

Gone was the respectful address. His voice had turned harsh.

Jeok Cheongang's smile broadened. His opponent was losing his composure.

"Much better. I'd rather bite down on a sword and die than keep hearing you call me 'Senior.'"

"Shut your mouth!"

CRUNCH!

The balance of power, which had been tipping slowly in Jeok Cheongang's favor, reversed in an instant. The fearsome power bestowed on the Blood-Sword Demon Lord by the mages—or sorcerers, as he called them—poured into his sword. A pressure as vast as Mount Taishan bore down on Jeok Cheongang.

Hup.

Jeok Cheongang caught his breath. A vein stood out on his forehead, and he felt his feet digging deep into the ground. Still, he did not retreat.

No—he couldn't.

What? Hold him off for just half a quarter-hour?

Beyond the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's shoulder, he could see the back of a certain insolent brat disappearing into the enemy ranks. The boy had thrown aside his Master, a man he revered as the heavens, like a worn-out rag.

A faint smile touched Jeok Cheongang's lips.

Treating this old man like a feeble geezer. The nerve of him.

He knew perfectly well that the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had the advantage. Jeok Cheongang had already spent a considerable amount of internal energy fighting the Black Ghosts. His opponent, far from tiring, had gained power beyond his own limits, just as the Southern Heaven Demon Empress once had.

But…

I'll show you why they call me the Fire King.

A hundred and twenty years. Every one of them had been a struggle.

He had fought enemies, every manner of inner demon, and even himself. Once, loneliness had consumed him.

Not anymore.

There was someone who trusted him more than anyone else in the world. He had something worth protecting with his life.

If you want, I'll hold out for half a year, not half a quarter-hour. I'll wait for you as long as it takes.

That was why the Fire King Jeok Cheongang would not break.

He could not.

FWOOSH—GRRRR!

His fiercely burning light-flames wavered against the immense blood-red Force. A roar like the heavens splitting apart filled the air as overwhelming power surged toward him.

It could not wipe the smile from his face.

“Come on, then.”

KWA-BOOM!

White and red energy clashed and mingled again and again, their collisions shaking everything around them.

All of it happened far behind a man cutting through the enemy lines like the point of a sharp awl.

From some point on, I could clearly feel the constant roars and the shock waves from the immense power.

Old Master.

His face came to mind.

Half a quarter-hour. Not even enough time to leisurely finish a cup of tea.

But in a fight between superhumans trading lightning-fast blows, it was plenty of time for someone to die.

That was exactly why I had to keep moving instead of turning back to check on Jeok Cheongang.

If I kill the mages, the Magic empowering the Blood-Sword Demon Lord will break.

It was one of the reasons I’d changed direction and left Jeok Cheongang behind. As long as the Magic held, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord wouldn’t go down easily. He might even keep getting stronger.

But cut off the Magic that had made him so powerful, and we could turn the tide.

Of course, as I’d expected, things weren’t going smoothly.

SHWISH-SHWISH-SHWISH!

Weapons whistled past my ears without pause. Flashes of light skimmed dangerously close to my body.

Sabers, swords, spears, and the occasional weapon of a shape I didn’t recognize. They came in all kinds, but had two things in common.

First, every one of them had been swung at me.

Second, bright light flowed over the countless blades.

Peak masters…!

Not just a few of them. There were only about a hundred enemies stationed in the rear, but every last one had reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy.

At their center stood someone radiating an especially powerful aura.

> **System Level:** 170 **So Gunak**

A hulking man enclosed from head to toe in jet-black armor.

Naturally, I didn't know his title. Even if I'd known who he used to be, it hardly mattered. The enemy in front of me had already lost his former self.

Black Ghost.

My heart sank, and not just because another formidable obstacle had appeared.

The last Black Ghost, who hadn't shown up on the battlefield, was still here. That made me think of one possibility I hadn't wanted to believe.

WHOOOM!

A heavy rush of air snapped me back to the present. My thoughts were anything but light, but my feet felt like feathers as I shot forward.

SWISH! KWA-BOOM!

The great saber missed me and tore into the ground, sending earth flying. As ice and dirt scattered in every direction, I thrust White Flame's spearhead forward with all my strength.

SLICE!

Its flashing arc sliced across the back of his neck.

But the feel of the strike traveled up the shaft to my fingertips. It hadn't gone deep enough to kill him.

He dodged?

I hadn't let my guard down like a fool. Every second mattered, and I'd put everything into that first strike. The spear's trajectory and timing had both been exact.

What I hadn't accounted for was just how many variables Magic could introduce.

> **System Level:** 173 **So Gunak**

Three levels.

That might sound like a small difference. In the realm of superhumans, it wasn't.

WHOOOM—KWA-BOOM!

His next strike was faster and stronger than the last.

No—a strike getting faster and stronger even now.

> **System Level:** 175 **So Gunak**

SHWEEEE!

The heavy rush of air sharpened to a shriek. His massive, blunt saber came crashing down like lightning, carving through the space before him.

KWA-KWA-KWA-BOOM!

The ground sank beneath the tremendous force. As I backed away to escape its shock wave, the sound of more than ten streaks of wind rang past my ears.

SLICE! SPURT!

Blood sprang from cuts across my body. I'd twisted aside the moment I sensed the danger, but it was too late.

No. They'd been too fast.

They'd grown stronger. Stronger than they were a moment ago.

I'd seen it clearly. At the last instant, the blades had gained speed and force, shooting toward me like flashes of light.

I'd felt it, too: the Black Ghost and the hundred or so Peak masters closing in from every side—and, beyond their shoulders, a distinct pulse of energy spilling down from the hilltop.

They're trying to stop me somehow. Before I can get any closer.

I wasn't the only one who sensed danger.

The twenty white-robed figures standing in a circle—the mages—must have felt their lives were in danger, too.

But I'm different.

Everyone fears death. Me. Them.

But what makes the difference in the face of that fear is the strength of one's Will and desperation.

Inventory open.

I spoke the command in my mind and threw myself forward with all my strength.

Toward the more than a hundred Peak masters, who had grown even stronger.

Toward the last Black Ghost, whom I had to get past.

PAPAT!

One step.

Every distance vanished, and time slowed.

At the same time, dozens of streaks of light blazed destructively, coloring the world around me. And a single bolt of lightning, more enormous than all of them combined, came crashing down toward me.

SHWAAAK!

Yeah. I knew it. I was one man against many, and the difference in our strength was plain to see.

But what the eye could see wasn't everything.

I have to get through. No matter what it takes.

Those trying to get past, and those standing in their way.

Those fighting to protect something, and those who had forgotten what they were meant to protect.

They had no Will. They had forgotten desperation. They couldn’t even remember the word *duty*.

But I wasn’t like them.

I knew what all of those things meant. That was why I could risk my life to keep going. Why I could throw myself into the oncoming attacks and strike with everything I had, down to my soul.

Just like now.

SHWAK!

White Flame’s spearhead tore through the air.

At the same time, I whispered the command I’d held back.

Summon Fire Dragon Armor.

Ding.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Chapter 1040

KWA-BOOOOM!

A deafening explosion shook the earth.

The shock wave burst out without warning, rattling everything around it. It reached beyond a radius of several dozen *jang*[3689], all the way up the steep hill.

Rumble.

“May I say something?”

The old man’s voice cut through the rumbling. Beneath a silver-white veil, red lips stirred.

“No. You may not.”

There was no trace of the woman who’d been rattled by the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s fury just fifteen minutes ago.

At his superior’s calm, almost icy reply, the old mage flinched.

“…Grand Sorceress.”

His voice was full of concern.

But the woman called the Grand Sorceress, standing at the center of the white-robed figures, paid him no mind as she spoke.

“Put your worries aside. What you’re afraid of won’t happen.”

“B-but…”

“But what?”

Ordinarily, the old mage would have fallen silent by now.

Dark Heaven’s hierarchy was mercilessly strict, and the woman before him could crush him like an ant with a flick of her hand.

But he had seen it clearly.

At the last moment, countless flashes of light had swallowed one man.

A young man who’d thrown himself toward certain death, so far beyond recklessness that it was as if he’d already given up on living.

The old mage knew his role. Swallowing hard, he forced himself to continue.

“But if this goes on, he may be in danger. As you know, if ‘he’ dies here, how are we to bear that person’s wrath?”

He was right.

Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

If a man who had drawn such keen interest from the absolute one met such a futile end, they too would die for failing their mission.

No—they *would* die. Without a doubt.

[3689] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The old mage believed there would be no exception, not even for the woman before him: his superior, and one of the absolute one's closest confidantes.

Of course, that was only what he thought.

Danger? Die?

The woman repeated his words, then gave a quiet laugh.

Beyond the finely woven veil, her black eyes remained fixed on the hill below.

Who, exactly?

"Pardon? Why, of course…"

The old mage was about to answer when—

FWOOSH.

The hazy cloud of dust at the foot of the hill split apart.

And, as if an invisible, razor-sharp blade had passed through it, the veil parted cleanly to reveal the scene hidden within.

"…!"

"…!"

The old mage—and everyone else on the hill—stared wide-eyed.

Amid ground devastated as if a meteor had struck it stood a towering figure.

"Th-that's…"

One mage pointed before he knew what he was doing. The gesture was pointless. Everyone was already looking.

No one could miss that nine-foot frame, with arms and legs as thick as pillars. Or the familiar black armor enclosing it from head to toe.

"Black Ghost…!"

A trembling groan escaped the old mage.

His brief shock gave way to despair as his gaze fell on the bloodied man lying at the Black Ghost's feet.

The man who must not die here.

Jin Taekyung.

It's over. All of it.

The old mage's vision blurred.

He'd taken a sliver of hope from the Grand Sorceress's composure a moment ago. That only made the shock worse.

Half the hundred elite fighters they'd kept back as guards had vanished, but that meant nothing beside Jin Taekyung's death.

All twenty mages thought the same.

At least, until the Grand Sorceress's quiet voice rang out the very next moment.

"As expected…"

The mages' eyes widened at the murmur, its meaning beyond them but its note of admiration unmistakable.

Then, all at once, they saw.

Rustle. THUD.

Far below, the Black Ghost crumpled like a rotten log.

Only now, with his enormous body falling away, could they see the silver spearhead lodged between his brows.

They could see it. But they could not hear—

Ding.

The clear chime meant for only one person.

It rang in the ears of the man everyone believed dead, but who still lived: the sound of his return to life.

> **System** - You defeated Lv. 175 So Gunak! - Level Up!

Warm light welled up from deep within his cooling body.

It stopped the blood seeping through the gaps in his red armor, shattered by countless strikes of Sword Energy and Force. It mended torn flesh and broken bones, rekindling the flame of life once more.

Huff.

His breath was hot as fire.

As if waking from a long dream, Jin Taekyung slowly opened his eyes. He looked up at the dark sky before him once again and muttered,

"Fuck, it's good to see you."

The moment the old mage saw it, he understood.

Danger? Die?

He understood what the Grand Sorceress had meant.

Who, exactly?

The Grand Sorceress had been right.

Jin Taekyung wasn't the one who now had to risk dying.

They were.

WHIP—GRAB.

The spear lodged deep between the Black Ghost's brows flew into its owner's grasp as if drawn by an invisible force.

No sooner had it reached his hand than it shot out in a flash.

SHWAAAAK—SPLAT!

Blue-black flames swept through the surviving enemies in a savage arc like a giant dragon's tail.

“Grand Sorceress!”

“We have to stop him, whatever it takes! If this goes on, he’ll—he’ll…”

Urgent shouts rose all around her, beginning with the old mage.

But the Grand Sorceress watched the horrifying, wondrous sight in silence, an inscrutable light in her eyes.

At last.

The quiet exclamation hovered on her tongue.

Even when the mages could wait no longer for her command and stepped forward with clenched teeth, she alone stood there, smiling quietly.

From the moment I first opened my eyes in Murim, I’d faced the same reality again and again. Put simply:

High risk, high return.

It had always been that way.

An adventure with no set ending always came with enormous danger. But the greater the risk, the more certain the reward.

Just like now.

Ding. Ding. Ding. BEEP-BEEP.

Chimes and warning beeps rang out in rapid succession, tangling together in my ears.

A message confirming I’d defeated the Black Ghost, the last obstacle. A Level Up. A holographic window telling me I’d recovered as a result.

And that final warning beep…

> **System** - Fire Dragon Armor has suffered severe damage from powerful energy! - Fire Dragon Armor has been automatically recalled to Inventory! It cannot be resummoned until the damaged sections are repaired to a certain degree! - Time until Fire Dragon Armor is automatically repaired: 3 days

It told me the divine weapon that had made this gamble possible had taken the hit. Despite the crazy stunt I’d pulled, it had kept death at bay, if only for a little while.

I actually survived.

Maybe it was because I’d come so close to death, but it still didn’t feel real.

I’d made the gamble hoping I would survive, of course.

I just hadn’t been a hundred percent sure.

If that damned Black Ghost had taken even a little longer to die, the best I could’ve hoped for was taking him down with me.

But…

SHK!

I was alive. I'd survived.

And just as I had from the beginning, I was still here, cutting down enemies without stopping.

My body was brimming with life—the reward I'd won for risking my life.

PUK! BOOM!

I drove my spear through three enemies in a single powerful thrust, then swept out a palm strike at those rushing in from my blind spot.

KWA-AAAA!

Flesh and bone melted in the terrible heat.

Of the fifty or so enemies who'd survived my clash with the Black Ghost, fewer remained by the moment.

Faster. Faster.

I gritted my teeth and pushed harder.

I had to end this fight as quickly as I could.

My mental strength had already been pushed to its limit. I was running on empty.

If the Level Up hadn't restored my body—if I hadn't been thinking of everyone still behind me—I might have collapsed already.

They won't fall until I bring them down.

I swung White Flame as if possessed.

I'd pushed the Middle Dantian's ability to its limit, and my mind had slowed noticeably. My hands and feet, guided by instinct and movements ingrained through endless training, swept through the enemy faster than I could think.

I was relying on instinct more than reason.

Even so, there was one last thread of reason I clung to: the reason I couldn't fall, and the greatest variable my enemies had.

Magic.

Maybe that was why my instincts, keener than ever as they raced ahead of my thoughts, picked up another change. I'd been wary of Magic all along.

WHOOOOOM.

Space trembled. The air trembled.

At the same time, desperate voices rang out in the distance.

"The power of the Wind Ghost!"

"The might to uproot mountains!"

FWOOSH!

Energy boiled up from the hilltop and hurtled toward me.

An invocation, followed by its manifestation.

But I knew this kind of body-strengthening Magic could only take effect if its target was still alive.

SHWAK!

White Flame's spearhead, wreathed in blue-black fire, tore through the air.

The terrifying ring of fire swept through a dozen or so enemies within the spell's range.

SHK! PUK!

Ten heads flew into the air.

At that very instant, pain shot through my side.

I'd been ready for it. Without slowing down, I turned and drove my elbow back.

CRACK! KWA-BOOM!

The enemy's face caved in, and he went flying. I pulled the dagger lodged deep in my side free and whipped my arm out in a flash.

SWISH—PUK!

With a dull thud, another enemy's head snapped back. Only about twenty remained.

"What is this…!"

"No! Stop him!"

Listening to the shouts of the white-robed figures—or rather, the mages—now tinged with fear, I could roughly guess what was happening.

There was a limit to the Magic they could use.

That was what set them apart from the mages I knew in the modern world.

And in the next moment, that realization lent force to my feet.

CRUNCH—BOOM!

The ground buckled, then melted.

Flamefire Path.

I shot forward in a single explosive burst. No one nearby could stop me now.

No matter how strong you made a hunting dog, it couldn't stand against a wolf. Even a thousand-year-old *imugi*[3690] couldn't ascend to the heavens without a dragon pearl.

Not even something inhuman could stop me.

"Taishan."

WHOOOOOM.

"Fall and crush him."

A voice I remembered rang out, and immense pressure descended on me as I shot forward like a streak of flame.

But unlike last time, I was ready.

[3690] In Korean folklore, an *imugi* is a serpent-like being associated with becoming a dragon.

I can see it.

I could feel it, too.

The flow of qi. A single line hidden beneath that immense power.

And…

Now.

SHK!

My spearhead crossed the space without a sound.

It cut through Taishan.

Chapter 1041

Magic was an unpredictable and powerful force.

It could strengthen allies, weaken enemies, and change the course of a battle in countless ways, from wide-area attacks to defensive barriers.

That was why mages were so highly valued even in the modern world, where the insane profession known as Hunter had taken root.

But if someone asked me whether mages were the most powerful among Hunters of the same rank, I'd answer without hesitation.

No.

Under the right circumstances, they could wield more power than anyone else on the battlefield. But they needed a few things in place first.

The first was allies who could protect them while keeping approaching enemies at bay.

SHING!

I cut through it.

There was no sensation of slicing through flesh and bone, no hot blood spurting like a fountain. And yet I felt it clearly.

I'd cut straight through something intangible and odorless that people called qi. The System knew it, too.

Ding.

> **System** - You successfully dispelled **Gravity Magic**! - **Qi Sense** has improved slightly! - You can now control qi a little more freely!

A translucent holographic window appeared as the System notification rang in my ears.

I paid it no mind.

I drew up every bit of qi sleeping deep within my body and kept moving forward.

SHWEEEE!

The several dozen *jang*[3691] between us vanished fast. As I closed in, the immense energy covering the hill surged more violently.

"F-Fire Ghost, answer our call!"

"Strange rocks and crags, block our master's enemies!"

The incantations came out in a rush.

Dozens of massive fireballs filled the air. Ahead of me, the ground turned over and a wall of stone rose high.

[3691] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

FWOOSH! GRRRR!

If anyone else had seen it—or even a seasoned master of the martial world—they would have stared in awe, calling it the work of supernatural powers.

But in all the vast world, I was the one exception.

Fire Ball. And Stone Wall, too?

The moment I recognized the newly manifested Magic, my face stiffened.

Was it because these spells were too much for even me to dispel easily?

Wrong.

Judging by their size, range, and power, even B-rank or upper C-rank mages could cast them.

The problem was that I'd just realized my earlier theory was wrong.

They weren't limited in the kinds of Magic they could use. They just hadn't used them.

Magic was valued not only for its power, but for its variety and all the ways it could change a battle.

Yet despite having both the ability and the opportunity, all they'd shown so far was body-enhancement Magic and Gravity Magic.

Why the hell?

The question filled my mind.

But the Magic reached me before I could find an answer.

KWA-AAAA!

The dozens of fireballs had been tiny when they were first launched from afar. Now, as huge as boulders weighing a thousand *geun*[3692], they sailed over the stone wall and fell toward me.

The heat alone would have taken anyone else's breath away.

But the heat in White Flame's spearhead as I brought it down on them was deeper and fiercer beyond comparison.

SHING—KWA-BOOOOM!

I dodged half and cut through the rest.

The fireballs exploded in midair, scattering brilliant flame in every direction. I burst through the acrid smoke and drove my fist toward the enormous stone wall blocking my way.

WHOOOM!

My fist cut through the wind—no, burned through it.

The art had none of the ever-changing forms or profound principles boasted by the other great sects. But for sheer explosive force and destructive power, it had no equal.

[3692] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand *geun* is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

Long ago, the third Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan had been obsessed with fist-and-foot martial arts, unlike his spear-loving master. He'd named the martial art he created:

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

CRUNCH—KRRR!

True to its name, the wall of strange rocks and crags gave way, breaking into hundreds, then thousands of pieces.

No—it melted and burst apart at the same time.

GRRRR!

The ground shook as if an earthquake had struck.

I passed beneath the boulders raining down overhead and shot toward the hill again.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

> **System** - You successfully dispelled **Fire Ball**! - You successfully dispelled **Stone Wall**! - **Qi Sense** has improved slightly! - You can now control qi a little more freely!

"He's—he's coming!"

"Arrows of Radiance, answer our call!"

As their shouts rose almost to screams, I stared straight at the hilltop.

Twenty people in white robes.

Some were vomiting blood from the backlash of having their Magic dispelled. Others were casting another spell. Still others trembled, their faces as white as their robes.

One person stood out because none of that applied to him.

So it's you.

The Grand Mage.

A great mage who had reached the very edge of truth—and an enemy I absolutely had to defeat. He was a man.

His voluminous robes couldn't entirely hide his slender figure. Red lips showed beneath his silver-white veil.

He was another formidable foe, one whose presence had been overshadowed by the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

He might also be the only person who could answer my question.

SHWISH-SHWISH-SHWISH!

Magic Arrow.

I swung my spearhead up toward the countless streaks of brilliant light shooting at me.

FWOOSH!

Blue-black Force surged like wildfire and swallowed the light.

No—as soon as I thought it had, everything there burned to ash, and new spells came rushing in.

POW-POW-POW! SHWEEEE!

The air and the ground below it were blanketed in lights of every color.

A spear of ice. A rain of fire. Blades of lightning and wind.

All of it came crashing down on one person.

Me.

The countless streaks of light merged and followed one another, each as powerful as a Peak Master's Sword Energy.

But that was all they were. They could never wound me.

SHING.

I cut through the ice spear with my own.

SHWISH-SHWISH! KWA-BOOOOM!

Moving as swiftly as Shifting Form and Position, I dodged the rain of fire falling all around me.

BA-BOOM!

The heat of Flame Divine Palm swallowed the lightning and blades of wind waiting for me.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Clear chimes rang in succession, announcing that I'd dispelled the Magic.

The pinnacle of mastery.

The high, densely wooded peak I'd built by surviving the brink of death again and again—none of their spells had come close to threatening it.

Here on the hill overlooking the blood-soaked battlefield, nothing could stop me now.

Not people. Not Magic.

"Plants sleeping beneath this earth, rise up and bind our master's enemies!"

RUSTLE!

I felt it before the incantation was even complete. I knew what it was.

The pulse of energy beneath my feet. The nature of this Magic.

But there was no reason to dodge, and no need to cut it apart.

Thick roots burst from deep underground and coiled around my whole body, binding me tight. I simply stepped forward in silence. That was enough.

CRUNCH. CRUNCH.

The stems, hardened like steel by Magic, trembled.

They were wrapped tight around my limbs, my waist, even my neck. I felt their pressure, reached out, and tore them apart.

KRRRUNCH!

Ordinarily, I shouldn't have been able to reach out at all. I certainly shouldn't have been able to take a step.

But…

That's what you think.

That was only what they thought, staring at me in disbelief.

To me, this was perfectly natural.

A Reward earned through one life-threatening adventure after another.

Pure physical strength that a simple binding spell couldn't restrain.

That strength, far beyond human limits—and the several *jiazi*[3693] of internal energy still surging endlessly from my lower dantian—made it possible.

CRACK! BOOM!

The stems binding my body burst apart in an instant.

They kept coming, persistent as living creatures. I trampled them again and again, then ripped them out by the roots.

So they could never rise again. And so whoever had cast the spell would collapse, spitting blood.

Ding.

Another chime announced that I'd dispelled the binding spell.

"Ugh—bleeegh!"

Another white-robed figure fell to his knees, vomiting dark red blood.

He looked like the oldest of the twenty mages. He was also the nineteenth to fall.

What that meant was clear.

One person remained.

While the mages under his command kept collapsing from the backlash of their energy, the Grand Mage stood alone on the hill without the slightest sign of being shaken.

No—more precisely, it was just him and me, now almost face-to-face.

"I'd only heard about you until now… I'm glad to see you in person."

His red lips moved beneath the closely woven silver-white veil.

His voice was calm, with what sounded almost like a hint of excitement.

"Crazy bastard."

At my heartfelt insult, a breeze accompanied by a low laugh stirred his veil.

"What an ill-mannered man. Cursing someone whose face and name you don't even know."

[3693] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

He was right.

I didn’t know this man’s name or face.

I already knew that even the supernatural ability granted to me by the System couldn’t reveal any information about him.

Otherwise, he wouldn’t dare speak to me like that with less than a *jang*[3694] between us.

WHOOOOOM.

I couldn’t see it, but I could feel it.

The immense, deep energy blocking the space between us.

Though we occupied the same space, it separated us as if we existed in different worlds. It was an extraordinarily solid defensive barrier.

“So you’ve been sitting up on that hill, scheming away, and this is all you’ve got?”

“Ah, I knew you’d be able to feel it.”

The Grand Mage nodded happily, then added,

“And I knew you wouldn’t try anything lightly in a situation like this.”

“…!”

“Oh, did I hit a nerve?”

I silently clenched my teeth.

He was right.

I had one attempt.

If I failed to break the barrier and take his life with that one strike, the Grand Mage would escape the narrow distance I’d managed to close.

That was why I couldn’t act rashly, even with every second counting.

But the quiet voice that slipped into my ears next was enough to shake me far more than anything he’d said before.

“Still, I’m a little disappointed. This isn’t all I prepared.”

“…What?”

“Shall I show you? I was getting a little bored anyway.”

At that very moment—

GROOOOOM.

In stark contrast to his bright, laughter-filled voice, an utterly dreadful amount of energy surged up around his slender body.

[3694] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 1042

Gooooom.

The instant Jin Taekyung felt the enormous energy surging around the Grand Mage, two words shot through his mind like bullets, wiping it blank.

The first was wide-area Magic.

And the second…

One Annihilation.

He knew it by instinct.

To stop the insane thing the man before him was about to do, he would have to make an insane choice of his own.

Only a desperate strike he'd thought he could never use again—a strike he had even less chance of surviving this time—could stop the wide-area Magic from activating.

He realized he'd already made his decision and laughed bitterly to himself.

Damn it.

He didn't want to die yet.

He wanted to live somehow, even if he had to struggle pathetically for it.

But there was no way.

No—there was only one way.

To break through the powerful barrier surrounding the Grand Mage and take his life with a single strike, he would have to burn up his own life.

Was he certain it would work?

No.

There was only a chance.

Would he survive, or die?

Death was far more likely.

But even so, that was enough.

It was the only way to protect the tens of thousands of allies still fighting on the battlefield—and the people precious to him among them.

All right.

That was enough.

A noble sacrifice or a pointless death.

He didn't know which it would be. But in this moment, these chaotic times demanded that Jin Taekyung become a hero, and he was ready.

Perhaps he had been for a very long time.

Fwoosh.

The wind stopped. The air trembled.

Time seemed to stand still. Hundreds of acupoints awakened, and he felt every muscle in his body, down to the last strand.

And then…

Qi flowed into the white spearhead.

Dark as the deep sea, flashing like lightning, burning like flame.

At last, those forces merged and swelled larger than ever before. Powerful enough to devour its wielder's life, the energy surged along the spearhead he held drawn back like a bowstring.

In that moment, it blazed with such dazzling light that it seemed to color the Grand Mage's eyes, hidden behind his finely woven veil.

This is…

The barrier couldn't fully conceal that destructive radiance. Fear seized the Grand Mage, along with awe for the young man before him and the unbelievable choice he had made.

At this rate, I'll die. Without a doubt.

He was certain. Once that terrifying strike was complete and launched, he and his barrier would vanish without a trace.

Jin Taekyung's life would scatter like ash as well.

But neither the Grand Mage nor the master he served wanted that.

We're both lucky, you and I.

A money pouch forced to bear more weight than it could hold would tear. Tie it shut before the full weight settled, though, and it would remain intact.

The difference was that narrow.

The Grand Mage's Magic was already a step ahead. Jin Taekyung's strike was a step behind.

That sliver of time—no more than an instant—changed both their fates.

Pour forth, flames of hell.

Fwoosh!

An immense energy exploded around the Grand Mage.

It began spreading far faster than Jin Taekyung had expected. He had only one choice left.

Shwoosh!

The spearhead tore through space.

At the same time, a One Annihilation larger than ever before, and therefore not even half-formed, finally met the barrier between them.

Gooooom.

A deafening roar made his ears ring, and white light washed over the hill.

Amid the faint pain coming from all over his body, the old Daoist steadied his ragged breathing.

Hoo.

His sweetish-smelling breath slowly dispersed.

Blood running from the wound on his forehead had stained his vision red. Through it, he saw two men standing tall as iron towers.

No—the instant he thought he saw them, they vanished.

Whish.

A whistle so faint it made his skin crawl reached his ears.

An alarm sounded in his mind. His thoughts raced ahead, ordering his body to dodge.

Move. Get out of their way, now.

But already badly wounded, his body could no longer move as it normally would.

Shhk!

Excruciating pain shot through him.

Two blades he hadn't quite avoided slashed his side and shoulder, and the tremendous energy within the steel tore deep into his body.

Hng…!

His vision blurred.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord steadied himself and swept his treasured sword out. Brilliant Sword Force flared along the blade, now only half its former length.

Bang! Bang! Baaang!

Three clashes, swift as lightning. Then a figure shot through the cloud of dust like a cannonball.

"Sect Leader!"

The Zhongnan Sect Disciples fighting amid the Dark Heaven cultists cried out.

At that moment, two figures appeared from nowhere and caught the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord as he flew backward.

Grind.

Only after sliding back about ten feet did they finally stop.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord coughed up dark blood. He moved his lips, looking toward the two men whose faces he could barely make out.

"Senior Brothers…"

"Damn it, don't say a word."

His eldest Senior Brother, the Roaring Fury Swordsman, snapped at him. Then his second Senior Brother, the Taeeul Merciless Sword, spoke with a grave expression.

"This is enough. Junior Brother, Sect Leader."

This is enough.

It was a short sentence, but the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord understood at once what it meant.

That was precisely why he couldn't believe it.

"Enough? What in the world are you…"

"We're out of time. The longer this goes on, the greater our sect's losses will be."

"Senior Brother!"

His cry rang with shock.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword pressed his lips together. Beside him, the Roaring Fury Swordsman gritted his teeth as he watched the two Black Ghosts slowly approach.

"He's right. We've already secured a way out. Give the order! Now!"

It sounded less like an appeal than a command.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord stared blankly at his two Senior Brothers.

"Are you… serious?"

Neither answered.

Unable to meet their Junior Brother's wide eyes, they kept their fearful gazes fixed on the Black Ghosts.

They knew how far what they were proposing strayed from the righteous path.

Seeing them like that, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord finally understood that this was real.

"…You were serious. Both of you."

What was he supposed to call this feeling?

It was strange.

They had spent their lives together, studying under the same Master. Yet they seemed unfamiliar now, as though he were seeing them for the first time.

Retreat. Retreat.

The word echoed through his hollow heart, and memories came to him, beginning with the day he first joined the Zhongnan Sect.

Even in that distant past, now buried in dust, the three of them had always been together.

He had been glad of it.

They were closer to martial artists than Daoists and sometimes caused trouble with their harsh words and actions, but they were his Senior Brothers.

When he was appointed Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect, they had been angry that they weren't chosen. In the end, they had accepted it and followed him.

When trouble arose with the Nanman Beast Palace during the Great Faction War.

When, only a year ago, their own mistakes had led to their humiliation at the hands of Jeok Cheongang and then Jin Taekyung.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord had stood up for them, stopping their critics and speaking in their defense.

And when both Senior Brothers recovered from their Internal Injuries at a speed that astonished everyone, no one had been happier than he was.

But…

“How did you come to this?”

He let out a quiet sigh.

He shrugged off the support of his two Senior Brothers, who stared at him with wide eyes, and gripped the hilt—all that remained of his beloved sword—so tightly it seemed ready to break.

“Do you remember? When Master gave me this sword, he said, ‘You need not strive to become a Daoist. Just live rightly. If you uphold your duty as a human being, that makes you a Daoist.’”

“…!”

“…!”

“If you want so badly to live, then go, Senior Brothers. I’ll stay. That is the only way not to disgrace the name of the Great Zhongnan Sect we inherited from our Master.”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord knew. So did the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

Everyone on the battlefield knew.

If the Zhongnan Sect, one of the forces holding the battlefront together at this point, withdrew, this battle would be a certain defeat.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord could not retreat.

Not him.

Grnk.

He bit his tongue. The sharp pain cleared his vision.

He stepped toward the two Black Ghosts approaching through billowing clouds of black smoke.

Squish.

His feet were heavy. So was his heart.

Perhaps he wanted to flee this place too.

But he didn’t stop.

He couldn’t run away.

That was the duty his Master had taught him to uphold as a human being.

Looking back, I wasn’t much of a Daoist either.

He had always envied Huashan for forging ahead and pursued only the Zhongnan Sect’s interests.

He’d grown the sect’s influence through wealth exchanged in collusion with those in power, and accepted Disciples for their talent rather than their character.

He had believed it was the right way to serve the Zhongnan Sect.

Yet through it all, he had never forgotten affection and loyalty.

Countless allies were still fighting for their lives here.

And in the most dangerous place of all, a young man faced a greater threat than anyone else.

Shame.

That was why he couldn't retreat.

"Come. No—this time, I'll come to you."

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's voice was thick with blood.

With eyes clearer than ever, he watched the two monsters approach and poured every last bit of his energy into the remains of his beloved sword.

Tsssss!

Brilliant Sword Force blazed.

It was the last flame he could kindle as Sect Leader of the Zhongnan Sect and as a martial artist.

"For the Great Zhongnan Sect."

The words barely left his lips before he hurled himself forward with all his strength.

"No!"

"Junior Brother, Sect Leader!"

He left his Senior Brothers' cries behind and flew toward the Black Ghosts like a moth to a flame. Two streaks of light waited for him.

Whish! Sshhh!

A massive battle-ax shattered the wind. A white sword blade sliced through space.

As he charged into that wave of destructive power, the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord knew with sudden calm:

This is the end.

Even with every ounce of strength he had, this strike would not kill them.

But then something happened that neither he, having accepted his death, nor anyone else on the battlefield could have foreseen.

Whoom—KWA-BOOOOM!

A blinding flash erupted in the distance, and an enormous shock wave slammed across the battlefield.

An explosion. A calamity.

He didn't know what to call it, but one thing was clear.

Grind!

The unexpected shock wave threw the two Black Ghosts off balance where they stood, while the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord's strike, already hurtling through the air, slipped between their two streaks of light.

Shhk!

The Heavenly River Thirty-Six Swords, wrought from dazzling light, cleaved through space.

Fwoosh.

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord swept past the two Black Ghosts like the wind. Then he—and everyone else on the battlefield—looked up on instinct.

At last, they saw it.

Flicker.

A sphere of flame so enormous it seemed not to belong to this world.

Hellfire dragged up from the depths of hell—Hell Fire.

Chapter 1043

For one instant, everyone on the battlefield stared at the sky, their eyes vacant.

Not a single person was an exception.

Not even the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, who had brought down two Black Ghosts thanks to what could only be called a stroke of heaven-sent luck.

Not even his two pathetic Senior Brothers, who had somehow gone somber and were now rushing to support their Junior Brother as he staggered, utterly spent.

Not even the Disciples of the Zhongnan Sect and the Gansu Murim Alliance, still fighting their separate battles on the blood-soaked snow.

Not even a father standing like a stone monument where his son had disappeared, or the Fire Dragon Pavilion members pouring every last bit of strength into chasing after their friend and leader, who had already raced far ahead.

Not even the Dark Heaven cultists, whose eyes were empty as they continued their mindless fighting.

Every living being looked at *it*.

A vast sphere of fire, unlike anything they had ever seen or heard of.

Grrrrrrr-BOOM.

Would this be the sound of an ancient giant roaring?

If the brimstone fires of hell recorded in old scriptures really existed, would they look like this?

A deafening roar poured down over everyone’s heads, leaving their ears ringing.

As the sphere fell from a dizzying height like a meteor, its terrible heat scorched the sky.

“A-aah…”

Groans rose from here and there.

Everyone froze where they stood. It was all they could do.

They were seeing it with their own eyes, and still they couldn’t believe it. Something beyond comprehension.

No—a calamity.

That was why no one knew its exact name.

No one except the person who had desperately tried to stop it, but failed in the end.

Hell Fire…!

In a world that seemed frozen in time, Jin Taekyung bit back the scream rising between his lips.

Hellfire, just as its name suggested.

One of the most powerful wide-area spells a human could wield—a calamity in its own right, capable of taking thousands of lives with a single cast.

No.

He knew its power better than anyone. That was why he'd tried to stop it.

He hadn't cared if he lost his life in the process.

If he could bring someone down in exchange—if he could stop the calamity—he could have told himself it was a decent end.

But in the end, he hadn't stopped it.

Right now, all Jin Taekyung could do was feel the weakness constricting his entire body and stare blankly as the calamity unfolded.

Even now... I have to do something. Somehow.

His vision wavered, no matter how desperately he wished otherwise.

And that wasn't all.

Every bone and muscle in his body screamed in pain, as if squeezed in a giant's fist. His dantian was already empty; he couldn't find even a trace of internal energy.

The One Annihilation he'd launched before it was complete.

That had been both misfortune and good luck.

Because it was incomplete, it hadn't shattered every defensive barrier. Because of that, Jin Taekyung had survived.

But for someone who had been prepared to give up everything, this was misfortune.

Shit.

The horrible aftereffects tore deeper and deeper through his body. Jin Taekyung shuddered without meaning to.

But he couldn't give up. He didn't want to give up on everything here.

Crack.

He clenched his teeth and moved his twitching arms and legs.

Gripping the spear shaft before it could slip from his hand, he used it as a cane and hauled his unsteady body upright.

"—Get out of the way! All of you!"

"Aaah! Aaaaaah!"

He heard the screams of those who had finally realized that the calamity falling from the sky, painting it red, was real.

He heard, too, the terrible confusion and fear covering the battlefield below the hill—and, somehow out of place amid it all, a calm voice.

"Why don't you just lie down? If you push yourself any harder, you really will be in trouble."

At the Grand Mage's composed voice, blood trickled from between Jin Taekyung's clenched lips.

"Shut your damn mouth, you bitch."

"That's a little harsh. When you think about it, I'm the one who saved your life."

Pop.

He appeared beside him as if he'd teleported—or, rather, he had used Blink, which was teleportation itself—and stopped less than a *jang*[3695] away.

More precisely, he stopped before the invisible magic barrier still standing between them.

"Honestly, you really surprised me just now. It gave me goose bumps."

His fingers, so thin and translucent that every vein showed through, gently traced the barrier.

The powerful barrier he'd personally layered dozens of times was down to a single layer, barely holding its shape. But he showed no sign of tension.

He knew Jin Taekyung could barely get to his feet under his own power, let alone attack.

"I'm only saying this out of concern, but don't waste your effort. You know, don't you? Killing me now won't undo what's already happened."

"Yeah. I know."

Jin Taekyung answered between ragged breaths.

But unlike his voice, his eyes weren't on the Grand Mage.

He watched the hellfire cross the blackened sky, moving slowly for all its enormous size, and continued.

"I also know you—and the rest of your lot—can never kill me."

He knew that better than anyone. Without hesitation, Jin Taekyung turned and gripped White Flame in a reverse hold.

He hadn't risked his life just to kill the Grand Mage.

He'd fought to protect one ally rather than bring down one formidable enemy—to protect tens of thousands of lives.

Please. Just once. One last time.

With a desperate prayer, Jin Taekyung wrung every last thread of energy from his body.

He made his body, ready to break at any moment, into a bow and set White Flame against its string.

Crrrk.

Excruciating pain filled his vision.

His already-weakened body screamed.

[3695] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The acupoints damaged by his earlier, excessive release of power burned even under the tiny amount of Scorching Yang Qi he could muster.

Grind.

But Jin Taekyung clenched his teeth and endured pain no ordinary person could even imagine.

He swallowed the blood pooled in his mouth along with the pieces of a molar that had cracked and finally broken apart.

Even now, the blazing sphere was drawing closer to the ground. He aimed his spearhead at it.

Only a faint shimmer of energy clung to the spearhead, like a heat haze. It could no longer be called Force.

“You really are a fool.”

The Grand Mage’s voice came with a sigh, but Jin Taekyung didn’t hear it.

He focused every sense and every ounce of strength on seizing his last chance.

Can I do this?

The question surfaced in his mind.

But Jin Taekyung already knew the answer.

No—or rather, anyone who saw this situation would give the same answer.

He couldn’t.

It was nothing but a foolish dream.

Nothing more than the desperate struggle and wish of a man who wanted to do everything he could right up to the end.

But…

If I couldn’t even dream a foolish dream like this, I never would’ve made it this far.

For one young man, life had been a long dream.

He’d been enraged by cruel reality, resigned himself to it, and even despaired for a time. But the young man had kept dreaming.

Then, one day, the dream became reality.

In that dream, he discovered an unexpected new goal and longing, great power—and an even heavier responsibility.

That was the one reason.

The reason he could never give up, even if he was a moth flying toward a blazing flame, even if he was a firefly destined to vanish in the heat of the burning sun.

Step. Scrape.

His trembling legs finally steadied and planted themselves in the ground like iron pillars.

His shoulder drew all the way back. Then, with a powerful step forward, he sent the spearhead aimed at the distant sky flying.

Go.

Whoom!

Every bit of strength one man possessed condensed, then burst forth.

Compressed air exploded with it.

Shwoooosh!

White Flame's spearhead tore through the wind. It split open space.

A streak of light crossed the sky, dyed in ominous darkness, and shot toward a sphere whose size and power dwarfed it.

It covered more than a hundred *jang*[3696] of distance, shrinking until it became a single point. Jin Taekyung watched it with eyes growing dim.

The spearhead hadn't reached its target yet.

But some things could be known without seeing them.

Like this.

It's no use.

An empty murmur echoed in Jin Taekyung's heart.

Failure.

He had nowhere near enough strength, speed, or internal energy to stop the Hell Fire the Grand Mage had prepared.

That was all. That was all there was to it.

Now that he'd poured out everything, Jin Taekyung had nothing left.

If anything remained, it was exhaustion weighing even more heavily on his body, and a helplessness greater than that.

And the enemy's sneer—the one who'd brought all of this upon him.

"Oh, don't be too disappointed. From where I was standing, it was a very impressive attempt."

The Grand Mage spoke with a mix of sympathy and amusement as he watched the spearhead, carrying the faintest trace of energy, finally touch the Magic he'd cast.

And at the same time, he heard it clearly.

The deafening boom that rang out all around them, as if the sky had split apart.

KWA-BOOOOM!

"…!"

"…!"

Jin Taekyung and the Grand Mage both stared wide-eyed.

Grrrrrrr-BOOM!

Hell Fire.

The horrifying hellfire, the enormous sphere of flame, was shaking.

"What is this…!"

The Grand Mage was astonished.

[3696] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The outcome had seemed as certain as a life-and-death duel between a child and a Supreme Peak master.

Jin Taekyung was exhausted, and the force behind White Flame's spearhead had been pitifully weak.

That was why he'd simply watched without even trying to stop him.

He'd known from the start that he couldn't do it.

To the Grand Mage, it was nothing more than a foolish dream.

And yet that single spear had changed the course of a sphere of fire hundreds of times its size.

It had bent part of the blazing flames and opened a rift in them.

"How…? How could this possibly happen?"

In the midst of a reality he couldn't begin to understand, the Grand Mage suddenly turned his head.

At last, he saw Jin Taekyung struggling to hold his unsteady body upright as he watched the unbelievable sight.

He saw the faint smile on Jin Taekyung's face, and his lips, caked with dried blood, moving.

"Yeah. Nobody wants to give up."

Jin Taekyung's voice came out with difficulty, but it rang clearly in the Grand Mage's ears.

"Me, too. And them."

"…!"

Just a few words.

But the Grand Mage felt something and whipped his head around. At the same time, he found the answer to the question he'd asked himself moments earlier.

Shwoooosh—KWA-BOOM!

Dazzling streaks of light shot up from the ground and rained down on the sphere of fire covering everyone's heads.

There were others who shared that young man's dream.

Chapter 1044

The Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il, suddenly wondered what he was doing.

There was barely enough time to escape this hopeless battlefield. Why was he still swinging his sword with all his might?

Shwoooosh!

Streams of Force raced along his blade and tore through the air.

The dazzling streak of light, aimed neither ahead nor behind but into empty space, crossed a distance of more than twenty *jang*[3697] and struck the enormous ball of fire in the blink of an eye.

KWA-BOOM!

The sphere shuddered with a deafening roar.

But it faltered for only a moment. Then the calamity resumed its descent as though nothing had happened, and despair filled the Roaring Fury Swordsman's eyes.

It's no use. I can't stop it.

He knew by instinct. He'd already given it everything he had several times.

He was worthy of being called a superhuman, yet his strength was nowhere near enough to stop that enormous fireball—a thing that might as well have been wrought by supernatural powers.

What the hell is this…

He could barely breathe.

The sphere was slowly covering part of the battlefield, its heat unbearable even from this distance. And the helplessness gripping his whole body was something he'd felt only a handful of times in his life.

But at that very moment—

Pop, sh-sh-sh-shk!

The Roaring Fury Swordsman sensed someone appear beside him. At the same time, he saw dazzling streaks of light surge forward.

Fwoosh!

This is…

His eyes widened.

Dazzling light spread. Even from more than twenty *jang*[3698] away, the heat that had warmed his skin vanished in an instant.

Dozens of streams of Force shot forward, woven as tightly as a net. He knew them at once.

"Junior Brother!"

[3697] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

[3698] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

KWA-BOOOOM!

His reflexive shout mingled with another deafening roar. Beneath the fiery fragments raining down from the collision, a familiar figure appeared.

“We meet again so soon, Senior Brother.”

His expression and voice were so cold that anyone else might have found them chilling. The Roaring Fury Swordsman murmured, almost groaning, at the sight of his Junior Brother, known to the world by that very demeanor as the Taeeul Merciless Sword.

“How did you get here…!”

His surprise held more confusion than joy, and even a trace of worry and anger. The Taeeul Merciless Sword answered calmly.

“What, did you think this Hwangbo Eom would obey you so readily?”

“You fool! What kind of nonsense is that? What happened to Junior Brother, the Sect Leader, and the other Disciples?”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman bellowed, living up to his fiery sobriquet.

Only moments ago, he’d left Hwangbo Eom to look after the Sect Leader—who had finally collapsed from exhaustion and injuries—and the surviving Disciples of their sect.

Hwangbo Eom should have been leading them in a swift retreat. Instead, he was here.

For a moment, the Roaring Fury Swordsman forgot everything around him and shouted at the top of his lungs.

“You idiot! If you’re gone too, who in the world is going to lead our sect…!”

“They say old habits die hard. You certainly live up to your sobriquet. Come to think of it, you’ve always been like that, Senior Brother—even as a child.”

“What?”

No answer came. Ignoring his Senior Brother’s incredulous stare, Hwangbo Eom swung his sword.

His face was as impassive as ever, but the veins standing out on his skin showed how much strength he was pouring into every strike.

Shwaak! KWA-BOOOOM!

Force shot from his blade and collided with the flames.

The fireball faltered again. Fragments broke away and fell toward the ground amid a drizzle of sparks.

“As I thought, this won’t be enough. Not on my own.”

“…”

“Are you ready for the Moon-Shattering Sword Formation?”

This time, Song Il was the one who gave no answer.

He glared furiously at Hwangbo Eom, gathered all his strength, and swung his sword upward.

Shhk, shwoooosh!

Their sword strikes, as different as their temperaments, flew side by side through the air as though competing.

No. They seemed about to collide, but instead they mingled, growing more powerful together.

As if to prove they had grown from the same root.

KWA-BOOOOM!

The roar was louder, the shock wave stronger than ever before.

The fireball's course shifted, if only slightly. Taking what encouragement they could from the sight, the two martial brothers poured out Force with everything they had.

Shhk, whoooosh!

They slashed, struck upward, and thrust.

Amid the ceaseless explosions, the two old Daoists could still hear each other speak.

"Don't worry about Junior Brother, the Sect Leader, and the other Disciples. So Pyeong will do his duty well."

"So Pyeong… I see. So that's how it ended up."

It was too late to change anything now.

Only then did the Roaring Fury Swordsman realize who was leading the Zhongnan Sect's survivors. His face darkened.

The Zhongnan Sect's thousand finest.

In less than half a *shichen*[3699], a third of them had been killed or wounded. Among those still able to move, few Disciples were ready to bear the sect's future.

Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan One Dragon.

The Zhongnan Sect's greatest prodigy, and one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes—the finest young martial artists of the Central Plains.

He had once been so lost in wine and women that he couldn't come to his senses. But since the dispute between the Taeeul Merciless Sword and the Yongbong Escort Bureau, he had grown remarkably, both as a person and as a martial artist.

Even so, the Roaring Fury Swordsman could not set aside his concern.

"He's still too young. You should have stayed behind."

"By that reasoning, you're the problem, Senior Brother, and we could go on forever. Besides, I was even younger than him during the Great Faction War. Junior Brother, the Sect Leader, was younger still."

"That was different."

[3699] A *shichen* is a traditional time period of about two hours; half a *shichen* is about one hour.

“I’d like to ask how, but I’ll let it go this time.”

Shwaak!

His blade tore through the air.

Spreading a net of Force with all his might, the Taeeul Merciless Sword added in a low voice, “At least back then, supernatural powers like this weren’t running rampant.”

KWA-BOOOOM!

A roar like the sky splitting open. Heat fierce enough to burn them at any moment.

At the center of it all was a fireball much larger than it had been only moments ago.

It might shudder, and pieces might break away, but the calamity kept falling, as inexorable as a mountain.

Closer now, it loomed larger still: hellfire that would devour thousands of lives.

“Can we… stop that?”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman was breathing hard. The Taeeul Merciless Sword, just as visibly exhausted, answered with a question of his own.

“What do I look like to you, Senior Brother?”

A silence passed, brief and yet seemingly endless.

But the Roaring Fury Swordsman had a good idea what his Junior Brother meant.

Right. They couldn’t stop it.

They were only human, and that was a power beyond their understanding, a force of supernatural powers.

If anyone could hold this mad calamity back even a little, it would be true superhumans—those who, in human bodies, had reached a realm comparable to monsters or gods.

“I must be going senile. I never thought I’d want to see that mad old monster, the Fire King.”

“For once, I had a similar thought. A moment ago, I saw some reckless brat flash before my eyes. It made me wonder if I’d really lost my mind.”

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

And the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

The two martial brothers would never forget them for as long as they lived.

Not for any good reason, of course.

“They can’t come, can they?”

“Why ask when you already know?”

The senses of Supreme Peak masters surpassed anything ordinary people could imagine. Reading the events unfolding across the battlefield, the two men already suspected that neither the old monster nor the young one from the Fire Gate Clan could come to their aid.

And at the same time, they held the contradictory wish that they didn't want help from either of them, whatever the circumstances.

Even now, they hadn't been able to let go of their grudge against the Fire Gate Clan's Master and Disciple.

And that grudge had led them to commit an irreversible wrong.

KWA! KWA! KWA-BOOOOM!

Explosions followed one another.

But the Force Song Il and Hwangbo Eom unleashed had grown noticeably weaker. The fireball was now less than ten *jang*[3700] away, its heat fierce enough to burn away the last of their will to fight.

Grrrrrrr.

It was hot.

A crimson-black shadow, unlike anything they'd ever seen and something they'd never experience again, covered part of the battlefield.

"Do you… regret it?"

The Taeeul Merciless Sword's quiet question slipped between parched lips.

Staring hollow-eyed at the sky, the Roaring Fury Swordsman answered.

"Yes."

Seeing his Senior Brother like that, the Junior Brother did not ask what he regretted.

Nor did Song Il ask whether Hwangbo Eom regretted it too.

They had exchanged only a few words, but everything had been said. Each was left with his own silent thoughts.

We should never have done it.

The two men had temperaments as different as their sobriquets, but they'd lived similar lives. In this moment, the same thoughts came to them.

Their peaceful childhood, spent honing their martial arts rather than learning to act with humanity and righteousness.

Their youth, steeped in blood and death, when they'd chased achievements instead of living by a martial artist's code.

The years of regained peace, when their black hair turned white and they swiftly gave themselves over to self-interest and desire.

And then—

"I hear you two went through quite an ordeal."

One day, after paying the price for their greed, they had been left with severe Internal Injuries and inner demons. Consumed by hatred, they had received a tempting offer.

[3700] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

“This is a rare elixir I managed to acquire. Its effects rival Shaolin’s Great Restoration Pill. It will be more than enough to heal your Internal Injuries.”

They had said they would not meet him, but the uninvited guest had managed to see them anyway. When the two martial brothers doubted such unbelievable generosity, he offered them something they could not refuse.

“This isn’t generosity. It’s a transaction. If you accept, you can settle an old grudge and help safeguard the Zhongnan Sect as well.”

They had hesitated. In the end, they accepted.

They’d spent their lives as the direct disciples of the Zhongnan Sect Leader, heroes of the Great Faction War and respected masters of the martial world. They couldn’t go on living with this indelible humiliation weighing on them.

They had to take revenge.

Even if they did not kill anyone, they had to inflict on the Fire Gate Clan the same humiliation they had suffered.

And the transaction would safeguard the Zhongnan Sect too.

They could not refuse such a sweet offer.

They had willingly taken the hand extended by the uninvited guest. No—by Sima Gong, the Black Night King.

Only months later did they come to regret that decision.

Now they watched the blazing flames slowly closing over their heads.

“How did you come to this?”

The Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord.

Their youngest Junior Brother had spoken those words in a hollow voice. Hearing the regret in it, they had understood what choice remained to them.

What they had to do.

“Run. There’s still time.”

“I refuse. You go, Senior Brother.”

“I refuse, too.”

Three *jang*[3701].

The enormous sphere of fire filled their vision. The two martial brothers stared at it, dazed.

“We never had a chance of stopping it.”

“That’s right.”

“Then why did you come?”

“For the same reason you did, Senior Brother. I felt I had to do something. Even if it was only this. And…”

Two *jang*[3702].

[3701] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

[3702] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

The heat and light pouring from the flames were so blinding that the Taeeul Merciless Sword closed his eyes.

Or perhaps he was too ashamed to face the world openly as he died.

"…I was ashamed. And I was sorry."

To the Master who had taught them humanity and righteousness.

To their youngest Junior Brother and the sect's Disciples, who had treated them as Senior Brothers despite how unworthy they were.

To everyone else.

And to a certain Master and Disciple who, unlike them—who'd strayed from the path long ago—still walked the righteous path.

"What a damned mess."

Whether the words slipped from the Taeeul Merciless Sword's lips or the Roaring Fury Swordsman's, the voice sounded more hollow than ever.

Fwooooooosh!

The heat and light pouring from the enormous fireball, extending across a radius of hundreds of *jang*[3703], were more magnificent than ever.

[3703] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

Chapter 1045

Whatever its type or purpose, two things could bring a spell's power to its limit.

First, the caster's immense mana.

Second, a Magic Formation that could gather and release that mana as efficiently as possible.

The magic wielded by the woman known as the Grand Mage had both. It could hardly have been more perfect.

Just as a masterwork sword was born after countless rounds of hammering and quenching, magic, too, could reach its greatest power when enough time and effort were devoted to it.

The Magic Formation had been completed while the hillside below turned red with blood. Once it activated, no one could stop it. And Jin Taekyung wasn't the only one who had some idea how powerful that enormous sphere of flame would be.

Fwooooooosh!

The world slowed.

Light and flame spread, slowly.

The fireball was still two *jang*[3704] from the ground, but the heat pouring from it was already horrifyingly intense.

It swallowed the wind and moisture around it, and the shadow of its flames spread over part of the battlefield. Fire King Jeok Cheongang watched it descend, stunned.

So this is… Magic.

The words *dark arts* had long since vanished from his mind.

Yes. This was Magic.

A spell wielded not by a human, but by a demon. Jeok Cheongang knew there could be no more fitting description.

He also knew that, at this moment, he was the only one left who could stop that terrible power from exploding.

Boom!

Flames burst from beneath his toes, and he shot forward like a flash of light.

But as Jeok Cheongang raced toward the fireball along the Flamefire Path, a chilling whistle sounded behind him. He ducked.

Shwoooosh! Slice!

The back of his head suddenly grew hot.

[3704] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Like a skilled butcher slicing meat, a streak of dark-red Force skimmed past Jeok Cheongang's head, slicing off a thin layer of hair and skin before cutting through the air.

"Where are you in such a hurry to go?"

His footing had wavered for the instant it took to dodge. By then, that butcher of a man had appeared in front of him at a speed surpassing Shifting Form and Position. Jeok Cheongang bit his lip.

"Blood-Sword Demon Lord, how dare you…!"

"How dare I? Even in that state, you still haven't figured it out?"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord smiled and gave the sword in his hand a shake.

Unlike Jeok Cheongang, who was covered in blood after their fierce battle, he had suffered only a few minor wounds. Now he was certain of the difference in their strength.

Certain of his advantage.

"You can't stop anything."

Shwaaak!

His sword blurred like a heat shimmer and came at Jeok Cheongang, tearing through the wind.

Bang! Bang! KWA-BOOOOM!

Its speed and destructive power defied imagination.

Enormous surges of Force lashed out and exploded in every direction.

Jeok Cheongang barely dodged the attacks pouring down on him, forgetting even to breathe. His gaze grew still.

I can't stop anything, huh? Yes, I suppose that's true.

If all he'd had was a fiery temper, the title of Fire King might have vanished from the world long ago.

But Jeok Cheongang had survived this long in Murim's mountain of sabers and forest of swords. Even now, with his life hanging in the balance, he faced reality with a cool head.

And he could see the one way past the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, the one way to stop the terrible calamity before it reached the ground.

Dance of the Fire God and Demon.

Yes. That was his only choice.

The final dance of a fire demon prepared to die.

The beginning and end of the Fire Gate Clan. Its fiercest blaze and its final ashes.

No flame burned forever. When the dance ended, its heat would fade and his body would burn away.

The stronger the spark within him, the greater the power of the blaze. And to sustain that growing fire, he would have to feed it more of his own life.

This will be the last time.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang knew it by instinct.

The dance about to begin would be his third—and his last.

His body held more Scorching Yang Qi than ever before. This time, it would not survive.

But he had no regrets.

Even if his body turned to ash and scattered, the spark he left behind would remain.

Even if Fire King Jeok Cheongang's flames died out, the spark called Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, would burn brighter somewhere in the world.

So…

That's enough.

Jeok Cheongang murmured the words to himself and twisted his body. Slipping through the dense net of Force surrounding him, he drew up every last bit of energy he possessed.

The Scorching Yang Qi he had accumulated over countless years—several *jiazi*[3705] worth.

And at last, he awoke the innate qi sleeping deep inside his body, a forbidden realm for martial artists.

No—more precisely, he tried to awaken it.

At that very moment, a massive surge of ink-black Force came flying from somewhere and blocked the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

Whooom—KWA-BOOOOM!

Power clashed with power, Force with Force.

A thunderous crash shook the surrounding air.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord emerged through the dust before it could billow up, recognized the intruder, and frowned.

"…Why are you here?"

"Go, Fire King."

The dry words slipped between firmly closed lips.

The intruder—no, Black Night King Sima Gong—kept his eyes on the Blood-Sword Demon Lord as he spoke calmly to Jeok Cheongang behind him.

"Before I change my mind."

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened at this unexpected appearance.

Sima Gong was the man he'd thought a traitor.

No, he'd been certain of it.

[3705] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

There was much he wanted to ask him, and much he wanted to say.

But he had almost no time. Jeok Cheongang put it all aside and sprang forward again, leaving only a brief Sound Transmission behind.

Stay alive, you filthy unorthodox bastard.

There was no answer.

Only the wind tearing across his body as he followed the Flamefire Path, and the terrifying crashes and shouts that rang through it.

"How dare a bastard like you—!"

KWA-BOOOOM!

The air shook. That was all.

Jeok Cheongang realized that Sima Gong had barely blocked the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's Force from behind him. Gritting his teeth, he pushed himself to go faster.

Moments.

That was all Sima Gong could hold out against the Blood-Sword Demon Lord as he was now.

He might die within a few dozen exchanges.

But…

That's enough.

A single finger's breadth could decide life and death, and a gap of a split second—divided and divided again—could change one's fate.

That was Murim. The world of superhumans.

Crack!

The ground sank beneath Jeok Cheongang's toes as he pushed off with all his strength. The world slowed, and pure-white flames surged up.

BANG!

No flame could move faster than light.

But in that instant, Jeok Cheongang crossed dozens of *jang*[3706] in a single bound. Nothing could hold him back.

If one chain bound him, it was time alone.

Damn it!

Jeok Cheongang swallowed the groan threatening to break from his lips.

His body shot forward faster than ever, hurtling toward the enormous sphere of flame.

It hung less than one *jang*[3707] above the ground now, its terrible blaze spreading over everyone's heads.

Just a little farther…!

[3706] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3707] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

But no matter how desperately he wished otherwise, events followed their cruel course.

Fwooooooosh.

Hot.

Even from more than twenty *jang*[3708] away, he could barely breathe.

Watching the flames swell at last before they touched the ground, Jeok Cheongang suddenly thought:

If only he'd had a few more seconds.

If only he'd been a dozen *jang*[3709] closer.

And…

If only someone other than him or Jin Taekyung were here. Someone who could stop this calamity.

Damn it.

Jeok Cheongang clenched his teeth and drove himself forward with the last of his strength.

He knew.

It was already too late to stop the enormous explosion.

But he had to keep going.

He belonged to neither the righteous path, the unorthodox faction, nor the Demonic Path. This was the path he had chosen.

If he didn't at least try, he felt he'd never be able to look that reckless brat of a Disciple in the face again.

"Come on!"

Jeok Cheongang unleashed an azure dragon's roar that shook the air around him and threw a punch with all his might at the calamity twenty *jang*[3710] away.

Then, in the next instant, he saw it clearly.

He heard it, too.

Shwooooooosh!

Just as the white light-flames of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist shot out in an explosion, a dazzling streak of light shone across the dark sky ahead of it, cutting through space.

Brilliant bolts plunged into the enormous, swelling sphere of flame.

Goooooooong.

In a world that seemed to have stopped, light and fire mingled in a distant flash that turned everyone's vision white.

[3708] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).
[3709] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).
[3710] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The sky and the earth split apart.

The world everyone knew gave way to a new world made of light.

At least in that moment, everyone on the battlefield—not just Jin Taekyung—must have felt that way.

Could this be…?

Fwoosh.

Before Jin Taekyung could fully recall the unbelievable sight he'd seen at the last moment, he felt his vision, which had been washed in blinding light, slowly return.

The white flash that had blinded everyone faded. In its place came a tremendous roar, arriving late, and flames surging up across the battlefield.

BANG! KWA-BOOOOM!

KOOOOROOM!

Was this what it would look like if the sun rained down from the sky?

Hundreds of fireballs, great and small, fell across a radius of more than a hundred *jang*[3711].

They crushed frail human flesh and bone, melted the ground, and evaporated snow mixed with blood.

Like flames of death—true to the name Hell Fire.

But death did not fall equally on everyone on the battlefield.

"Ah."

The groan that escaped someone's lips did not belong to Jin Taekyung.

The Grand Mage gazed silently at the inferno below the hill.

More precisely, at the Dark Heaven cultists collapsing into charred lumps without even a chance to scream.

Why?

She felt no sorrow at the sight of her allies dying so horribly.

Only bewilderment.

Why had the fireball that should have exploded in the midst of the enemy broken apart and swept through her own forces instead?

Among the roughly thousands of casualties, why did the enemy number fewer than a hundred?

Those questions filled her mind. She had watched only Jeok Cheongang in the final moments, but someone else had seen it all—and already knew the answer.

"Took you damn long enough."

[3711] A Korean *jang* is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“What?”

The Grand Mage turned at the voice behind her and saw Jin Taekyung smiling, weakly but unmistakably.

He was looking somewhere far beyond her shoulder. Something golden glimmered faintly in his eyes.

“Damn old hag.”

“…!”

At that instant, the Grand Mage understood something and spun around in a hurry.

At the same time, she saw the answer to her question with her own eyes.

Shwoooosh!

The streak of light that had torn the fireball apart—the Force arrows.

“Bow Saint…!”

Chapter 1046

Among the tens of thousands of allies and enemies locked in a brutal fight across the vast battlefield, killing and dying, no one noticed at first.

Not the dazzling white flash that had flown in and shattered the enormous ball of fire.

Nor the Force arrows still raining down over the slopes of the Great Snow Mountain.

Shwip, shwip, shwip!

One, two, three. Then ten.

Ten streaks of light burst forth one after another, tearing through the air as one.

Though each had been loosed a fraction of a moment after the last, the dazzling streaks flew side by side across more than two hundred *jang*[3712] and struck the battlefield.

More precisely, they struck the great and small fireballs falling where they had no right to fall.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Overlapping explosions roared across the battlefield, and the heat from the collisions swept over the ground.

Fwoosh, sizzle!

Collars blackened. Hair melted away.

But to those who had already seen death coming in the spheres of flame hurtling toward them, such pain was nothing.

No—their shock was so great that, for a moment, they forgot the pain altogether.

“H-How…? Cough.”

The old Daoist, the Taeeul Merciless Sword, coughed up a mouthful of blood. He couldn’t finish his sentence; the corners of his eyes trembled.

At the last moment, he had given up everything and closed his eyes. He couldn’t believe he was still among the living.

Beside him, though, someone who had watched death bear down on them reacted differently.

“Heh. Heh…”

The Roaring Fury Swordsman let out a weak laugh, not even noticing that one of his arms had been burned black.

He had wanted to die like this. He deserved to die.

And yet he had survived.

Thanks to help he had never expected.

[3712] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Two hundred *jang* is about 606 m (1,990 ft).

Today, he had seen that destructive, dazzling flash again—the one he'd witnessed in his distant youth, when his now-melted white hair had still been black.

Bow Saint. Is it really you?

An incredible coincidence? Or Heaven's grace?

With those words echoing in his heart, the Roaring Fury Swordsman squeezed out what strength remained and rose to his feet.

He didn't know whether this was mere good fortune or fate decreed by Heaven.

But one thing was certain.

If there was a reason they were still alive, it was to pay for the sins they had yet to atone for.

"…Primordial Heavenly Venerable."[3713]

At last, the Roaring Fury Swordsman planted both feet on the ground. For the first time in ages, he invoked the Primordial Heavenly Venerable and looked up at the sky.

Shaa.

As if answering his call, a ray of light slipped through the black clouds blanketing the sky.

Beneath that light, the Zhongnan Sect Disciples—whom he'd thought had already left—were sweeping through their enemies.

Shing! Slice!

Swords flashed, scattering blood.

Beneath fireballs raining down only on their enemies, a desperate yet powerful battle cry rang out.

"Disciples of the Zhongnan Sect! Don't you dare retreat!"

"Yaaah!"

KWA-BOOM!

Rrrrmmble!

Flames surged endlessly, and the earth heaved.

Even as they were charred black, the Dark Heaven forces advanced as if possessed, chanting words of praise for the Lord of Heaven.

Yet the Zhongnan Sect Disciples, now fewer than five hundred, did not stop for a single moment.

"Our path is here!"

Zhongnan One Dragon, Hyuk Sopyung.

His cry, ragged as if he were coughing up blood, roused everyone from their exhaustion.

[3713] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is one of the Three Pure Ones, the highest deities in Daoism.

The sight of the Disciples fighting with death already accepted, together with the Force arrows raining down one after another, halted the Gansu Coalition Army's retreat as defeat loomed.

"Damn it! Attack!"

"Now! Push them all back!"

"Yaaah! You fucking bastards!"

Unorthodox factions, orthodox factions, dark-path figures. Even the imperial army.

They were jumbled together as chaotically as the battle itself. They still couldn't make sense of what was happening, but all of them knew it instinctively:

If they didn't seize this chance now, they'd never get another.

And at the front of the group charging at the enemy again with screams that sounded like cries of anguish was a band of fighters who hadn't retreated for even an instant—not from the beginning, not now.

"Uoooooh!"

Whoom!

The sound of the weapon cutting through the air alone sent a chill down the spine.

With a battle cry like a beast's roar, the massive two-section staff swept through the enemies blocking the way.

KRAK-KOOM!

Blood and flesh flew in every direction.

Perched on the shoulder of the giant who stood out even on this battlefield, a small, foreign old man spat out a piece of flesh that had landed in his mouth and screamed.

"Hey! To the side! Look to the side!"

But before Taishan could make sense of Namho's shout, seven enemies rushed in from the flank, swinging Sword Energy.

Shing! Slice!

Three weapons cut through the space first, cleaving their necks and chests.

Splaash!

Amid the spray of blood, Soul-Chasing Guest Song Ilseom shook the sticky blood from his willow-leaf saber and spoke.

"Is everyone all right?"

Namho had had his mouth open and swallowed a mouthful of blood. He answered, "No. My stomach's churning."

Thwack!

With a horrifying impact, Taishan felled another enemy—or rather, smashed him halfway to pieces. His voice was unusually subdued.

"Namho. Don't throw up. Not until we find the Lord."

"Look at this little shit. Is that how you talk to an old man suffering at his age?"

"Then why'd you come? Did someone threaten you with a knife?"

"…!"

Namho was at a loss for words. Ju Hwaran, cutting down enemies with movements as graceful as a dance, spoke up.

"We're all right, too. I'm just worried about the Pavilion Master."

Hyuk Mujin clutched his side, where a long gash had opened during the fight, and muttered, "I'm hurt, though…"

"Everyone's fine. So stop hesitating and let's get to the Pavilion Master."

"No, why didn't you even ask—"

"Pavilion Master. Danger. Urgent."

Hyuk Mujin immediately shut his mouth. Ma Junggeol, the leader of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang, who had somehow ended up here with them, looked sadly from the dagger stuck in his thigh to Ju Hwaran and back.

"Do you have something to say?"

"Young Lady, well. It's just…"

"You don't."

"…Right. Let's say that."

At the sight of Ju Hwaran, whose eyes had begun to gleam, Ma Junggeol lowered his head gloomily.

They were crazy.

There was no doubt about it. These people were completely insane.

Why did I come all the way here?

He didn't know.

He'd blinked a few times, and somehow he was running with them. Before he knew it, he was fighting on the front line.

How could anyone come through a battle like this unscathed unless they were a Supreme Peak master?

He'd been slashed by a sword and stabbed with a dagger in the thick of the fighting.

But he had to keep fighting.

No—he was being told to keep fighting.

Shit…

More than ever, Ma Junggeol wished his sworn brothers were here.

Even the face of Great Sir, who did nothing but talk nonsense, floated before his eyes.

You said you'd bring him here in time. You damn bastards.

Swallowing back tears, Ma Junggeol glanced behind him for no particular reason.

The Great Snow Mountain—perhaps the last sight he'd ever see—still stood magnificent and radiant, as it always had, even after tens of thousands of unwelcome visitors had left it behind…

"Hm?"

For a moment, Ma Junggeol doubted his eyes.

It wasn't because of the streaks of light pouring down the slopes of the Great Snow Mountain and into the battlefield one after another.

He already knew from these unsettling companions that the legendary Bow Saint had appeared.

But…

What's that?

What caught Ma Junggeol's eye was a golden wave flowing down the Great Snow Mountain.

The Great Snow Mountain was always white, blanketed in snow that never melted.

In spring, summer, fall, and winter.

It had been that way for a thousand years, and it would remain so a thousand years from now.

But today, at this very moment, was an exception.

Whoooosh!

The wind howled.

Snow scattered from the ground in the wake of figures that had appeared out of nowhere in the mountain range and were racing forward like streaks of light.

They ran down the steep mountainside as if it were flat ground, moving like a single wave.

A golden wave, its dazzling radiance undimmed wherever it went.

"The Embroidered Uniform Guard…!"

As someone's cry, thick with emotion, swept across the battlefield, a thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards in golden armor raced down the mountainside like a wave, gathering speed.

All the while, one word echoed in their minds: victory.

And their commander's voice rang clearly in their ears.

"Do you see them?"

No one answered the question from Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

Only their aura, simmering like water in a cauldron, steadily grew stronger.

“Our enemies are there. Evil men who defy the natural order and seek to plunge the world into misery.”

More than a hundred years had passed since the age of warring heroes ended and a new dynasty took its place.

The hero of the Zhu clan ascended the throne and at last became the father of all his people. His descendants, the dragon-blooded heirs, called themselves the Sons of Heaven and firmly established their authority.

From among the countless people, those with the greatest martial skill and loyalty were selected and dressed in golden robes and armor. Thus was the Embroidered Uniform Guard born.

“They have thrown the imperial court into turmoil and sought to bring down the nation ruled by His Majesty the Emperor!”

As Jeong Hogun’s voice grew stronger, a thousand pairs of eyes glinted beneath their low-set helmets.

From Zhejiang Province, where the Imperial Capital stood, all the way to Shanxi.

Then through Liaoning and Hebei—and, as though that were not enough, across half the continent to Gansu.

It had been a grueling journey.

It would be a lie to say they weren’t tired. Even the Great Nation’s finest guards of the Imperial Family did not have bodies made of steel.

But the resolve and loyalty they carried in their hearts were harder than steel and shone as brightly as gold.

Go. You are my sharpest sword and my shield. Protect the Marquis of Shangshan, benefactor of the Imperial Family, and put his enemies to the sword.

The thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards still remembered it vividly.

No—they would never forget it for as long as they lived.

The Son of Heaven they had met the day before leaving the Imperial Capital.

The smile he had worn despite his sickly complexion as he spoke of Jin Taekyung, the Marquis of Shangshan. And his final command.

Remember. His enemies are my enemies.

As the Emperor’s commanding voice echoed in their ears, Jeong Hogun cried out,

“Do you all remember the imperial command from that day?”

At their commander’s question, they answered.

In their own way.

Clang, clang, clang!

Countless weapons finally emerged into the open, glinting in the light. Beneath their helmets, their eyes shone toward the enemies drawing rapidly closer.

A thousand weapons shimmering with tangible qi.

A thousand pairs of eyes radiating suffocating fighting spirit.

And a thousand masters, each possessing both.

The enormous golden wave covered the mountainside and poured toward the battlefield.

No—it became a wave that swept away everything in its path.

Shing! KWA-BOOM!

The instant the Force arrows fired by the Bow Saint vaporized the enemy ranks—

KRAK-KOOM!

The thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards drove through the opening like awls and changed the course of the battle.

Chapter 1047

If you asked what mattered most in deciding the outcome of a battle, every single person would give the same answer.

The quality of the troops—or their numbers.

But ask a general commanding an army, and he would answer differently.

He would name the two words that flashed through the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's mind at that very moment.

Momentum.

There was no doubt about it.

The enemy's momentum—the tide of battle—had changed.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord suddenly felt the air grow hot.

Their fighting spirit, which had been fading little by little like a campfire soaked by drizzle, was flaring up again. The shouts they raised with all their strength grew louder and fiercer.

An emotion close to desperation. A resolve to face death.

Weapons swung with their final spark of life, as if their wielders had never once considered giving up.

And then—

Shwaaa!

A dazzling streak of light cut through the air ahead of them.

KWA-BOOOOM!

A flash packed with terrible destructive force swallowed dozens of Dark Heaven cultists in an instant.

The explosions of fireballs, large and small, had already opened gaps in the cultists' ranks. Now another powerful streak of light shook their once-solid formation.

All the enemy needed was a spear to slip through that opening and pierce their heart.

Something like…

A golden spear called the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

KRAK-KOOM!

Deafening shouts mingled with thunderous booms.

The two sides collided. Blades swung like lightning, lives were lost and spared, and a thick mist of blood blanketed the area.

It took only an instant for the golden wave that had swept down the steep slopes of the Great Snow Mountain and charged onto the battlefield to turn red.

Slice! Thud-thud!

A flashing blade severed a neck in one stroke. A sharp spearhead pierced a chest.

Each guard had reached at least Supreme First Rate, and some had attained the Peak realm. That was how they had earned the honor of protecting the Imperial Family. The Great Nation's most powerful fighting force cut and stabbed through everything in its path.

Their fierce shouts proclaimed why they had come to this battlefield.

"Long live His Majesty the Emperor! May His Highness the Imperial Younger Brother live a thousand years!"

"For the Marquis of Shangshan!"

"Attack!"

Shwish-shwish-shwish!

With the fanatically loyal guards at their head, more than twenty thousand surviving Coalition Army soldiers charged forward.

Some sought revenge for their comrades. Others fought for a greater cause.

Their reasons and aims differed, but they all wanted the same thing.

Victory.

And the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who felt the scales of battle tipping rapidly in the face of this unexpected turn, wanted a glorious victory here today just as much as they did.

"You've got to be fucking kidding me…!"

A groan escaped through his clenched lips.

The battle was unfolding in a direction he had never expected.

The Bow Saint—and now the Embroidered Uniform Guard?

The Bow Saint was one of the Three Saints; nothing more needed to be said about her. The Embroidered Uniform Guard, directly under the Imperial Family, was the Great Nation's sharpest sword.

His side still held the advantage in numbers, but he could no longer be sure they were stronger overall.

And now that this powerful reinforcement had restored the momentum of the more than twenty thousand enemy soldiers, they were charging wildly. Unease began to take root in one corner of the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's mind.

No… No, that can't be.

He tried desperately to reject the word that had appeared in his mind without warning.

Defeat.

Even now, when he had become more powerful than ever, he could feel himself shrinking from the thought.

The sorcerers are still here. The Grand Sorceress is, too. If that bitch can do what she did before, we won't be outmatched.

But why?

The enormous ball of fire that had stunned even him, though he was on her side, had not appeared again.

He sensed neither another spell nor a surge of qi heralding one.

…*Why?*

Could something have happened to the Grand Sorceress in that brief time?

His heart lurched, and he turned to check what was happening on the hill.

Or rather, he tried to.

Someone who had been watching him calmly spoke up.

“Things aren’t going your way, are they?”

Black Night King Sima Gong.

At the words that passed between his bloodied lips, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s face twisted like a fiend’s.

“What?”

“I understand. Sometimes things turn out that way.”

Sima Gong continued calmly, though his voice was weary. He looked at his arm—or rather, the shoulder where the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had brutally torn it away.

“Half an hour ago, I never imagined I’d end up like this either.”

He wasn’t saying that merely because he had lost an arm.

Sima Gong was half-submerged in a pool of blood. Thick blood that belonged to him alone.

Yet the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who had struck down the traitor in his path in moments, trembled with rage, not the joy of punishment.

“If it weren’t for you—if it weren’t for you…!”

Everything had gone badly wrong.

Under the original plan, Sima Gong was supposed to order the Gansu Coalition Army to retreat at the right moment, leaving the Blood-Sword Demon Lord an easy victory.

That had been their bargain.

If Sima Gong helped Dark Heaven win in Gansu, they would use the province as a foothold to seize the Central Plains. In return, they would recognize his ownership of Gansu and Shaanxi.

A secret bargain, struck on terms both sides found reasonable.

And part of it had already been carried out successfully.

Not here at the Great Snow Mountain, but in Dunhuang, at the western edge of Gansu Province.

“Was this your plan from the beginning? Did you use the Kongtong Sect—of all people—as a mere decoy, just to win today and convince us you were still our spy?”

Questions poured out of him in a rush.

There was no time to waste. He ought to have killed this traitor, whom he could have torn apart without feeling satisfied, and begun salvaging the situation at once.

But the Blood-Sword Demon Lord still could not believe his judgment had been wrong. He had to hear the answer.

The Black Night King Sima Gong he knew was an unorthodox man to the bone. To survive, he would join hands with the devil himself, let alone Dark Heaven. He was a pest worse than a bat.

That was why the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had chosen him for the bargain. Even so, he had held on to his last doubts right up until he set foot in Gansu.

Only after he won a resounding victory over the Kongtong Sect guarding Dunhuang, using the information Sima Gong had given him, had he finally let those doubts go.

“Answer me! Now!”

Anyone else would have reacted the same way.

The Kongtong Sect had resisted fiercely in Dunhuang and suffered terrible losses. No one, however willing to sacrifice the few for the many, would have dreamed of using a member of the Nine Sects and One Gang as bait for a temporary ruse.

At last, under the overwhelming aura radiating from the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, Sima Gong’s tightly closed lips parted.

“I’m not a madman. I’m too rational to commit the lunacy of betraying someone a second time. That’s why I joined hands with you.”

His words confirmed what the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had thought.

But the answer he wanted only left him with a bigger question.

“Then why the hell—”

“Why? Why did I do this? Well…”

Sima Gong cut him off. He blinked weakly and asked himself the same thing.

Why had he made such a foolish choice?

When everything had been going smoothly, why had he crossed a river he could never return from?

Then he found himself thinking of someone who was not here—and should not be—and smiled bitterly.

“Maybe I lost my mind for a little while.”

“What… did you say?”

“But it’s a damn good thing I did. It worked, didn’t it?”

In the end, the moments Sima Gong had spent holding back the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had not changed the course of the battle. But Fire King Jeok Cheongang, whom he had helped, would never forget them.

That was enough for Sima Gong.

Even if he died, the Black Dragon Demon Gate would have at least some measure of absolution, enough to survive.

His heir, who wasn't here, would live and make everything Sima Gong had passed down even stronger.

"I'm tired. Time to rest."

The old unorthodox sect leader spoke calmly to the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who stood frozen with his eyes wide.

Then he added the one thing he had long wanted to say to the fanatic before him, the man who had betrayed the Heavenly Demon to serve a new master.

"Go ahead and kill me, you bat-like Demonic Cult bastard."

"…!"

Grind.

A chilling scrape came from between the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's clenched teeth.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord clenched his molars as if to crush them, then raised his sword, pouring his rage into its tip.

He aimed it at the traitor who had ruined a plan that should have succeeded—who had dared to throw filth across the path of the mighty Lord of Heaven.

Shwaaa!

But just as the blade, wrapped in dark-red Force, was about to fall like lightning—

Shing! KRAK-KOOM!

A streak of light flew in from somewhere and struck the flat of the blade dead on.

Slice!

The sword veered off at the last moment and split the ground instead, as easily as a knife cutting tofu. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord recognized the streak of light and shouted, his voice boiling with fury.

"Bow Saint…!"

As if answering his call, another Force arrow came flying through the crumbling ranks of Dark Heaven's cultists.

Shwish-shwish-shwing!

Five streaks of light illuminated the surroundings. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord gritted his teeth, and his figure blurred.

Bang! Bang! KWA-BOOOOM!

Explosions and thunderous booms followed his sword as it moved faster than sound.

Considerable force traveled through the trembling blade into his hand, but that was all.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord easily cut or deflected every Force arrow the Bow Saint fired. He bared his teeth in a grin.

“So this is all you’ve got?”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord remembered something his moment of doubt had made him forget.

That’s right.

With the sorcerers’ help, he was stronger now than he had ever been.

Even if the Bow Saint, one of the legendary Three Saints, had appeared, she was no match for him now that he had surpassed his limits.

I don’t know why that insolent bitch, the Grand Sorceress, is still quiet…

Tzzzz.

Beyond the blazing Force, a sinister blood-red light glinted.

“Come on. I’ll take you all on.”

And in the very next moment, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord realized—

“Now that’s good to hear.”

—there was another fact he had briefly forgotten.

“Joining forces to take on one man at my age was going to be embarrassing. You’ve set my mind at ease.”

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s pupils trembled as he spotted the old monster of Mount Jiuhua. A kindly smile rested on Jeok Cheongang’s lips, utterly at odds with the terrifyingly intense flames wrapped around both his hands.

Chapter 1048

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared at the two figures before him, his gaze wavering.

It was a strange sensation—one even he, a fiend who had made his mark on an entire age, had experienced only a handful of times.

Beneath a sky buried in storm clouds, countless enemies and allies were locked in a desperate battle. And yet it seemed as though those two alone filled his field of vision.

That was how much weight and meaning their titles carried: Fire King and Bow Saint.

All the more so when two living legends appeared in one place.

I can't see an opening…

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord swallowed without realizing it.

Not a hundred enemies. Not a thousand. There were only two people before him.

And yet those two made him feel as if he were surrounded on all sides by an army of more than ten thousand.

No—the pressure was greater than that.

Step.

For an instant, three footsteps sounded together.

Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint slowly closed in from either side. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord instinctively stepped back, then belatedly realized what he'd done and flushed.

He'd been pushed back.

By their aura. By their fighting spirit.

And Fire King Jeok Cheongang was not the sort of man to politely overlook it.

"What happened? A moment ago, you said you'd take us all on. Changed your mind already?"

"…You damn old monster."

"That sounds good today. Go on, say some more."

"What?"

"Are your ears already failing you, you little brat? I said keep running your mouth."

Jeok Cheongang grinned and continued.

He was visibly wounded, but a fierce heat still burned in his voice and on his face.

"Come to think of it, every bastard who's talked to this old man like that has ended up dead. Every last one."

"…!"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord's eyelids quivered.

It was an obvious taunt, but he could feel that Jeok Cheongang wasn't just putting on a show.

No matter how far he'd surpassed his former limits, it was hard to imagine him gaining the upper hand against both the Fire King and the Bow Saint at once.

Shwaak!

And then, at that very moment, a streak of light cut through the air. For all its dazzling brilliance, it was more than enough to deepen the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's unease.

Rrrr, KWA-BOOM!

A Force arrow came flying without warning.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord reacted at once, batting away the terrifying streak of light. As he tightened his grip on the sword hilt trembling from the impact, a graceful figure emerged through the cloud of dust.

Swish.

Her steps were so light they seemed weightless.

Her dust-covered clothes fluttered, proof of the punishing journey she'd made across half the land without a moment to catch her breath.

But the woman's face, visible above them, was flawless, and her eyes shone cold and bright as she watched her enemy beyond the dust cloud.

Three jang[3714] ahead. Three chi[3715] to the left.

So Gyo—no, the great martial artist known as the Bow Saint—shot forward and gripped her beloved weapon.

At the same time, three streaks of Force gathered along her white fingers as they flashed into motion.

Pa-pa-pat!

The dust cloud split apart. Force arrows, carrying power greater than lightning, cut through everything in their path.

Before the Blood-Sword Demon Lord could even see past them, he felt a surge of power on the other side. He swept his sword through the air with all his strength.

Whoooom!

A horizontal slash that seemed capable of cutting through even Mount Tai.

Dark-red Force swelled around the blade, then swept aside the Force arrows with speed and strength far beyond human limits.

KWA-BOOOOM!

[3714] A jang is ten ja, a traditional Korean measure of length. Three jang is about 9.09 m (29.8 ft).

[3715] A chi is a traditional Korean measure of length equal to 3.03 cm (1.19 in). Three chi is about 9.09 cm (3.57 in).

The air burst in every direction. The Force that had swallowed the streaks of light shot straight ahead.

Rrrrmmble!

It didn't merely shake the earth. The strike laid waste to everything in its path.

But the destructive trail of that blood-red flash held no sign of the enemies the Blood-Sword Demon Lord was looking for.

Only two different whistles tore in from a blind spot.

Fwoosh! Shing!

In a world that seemed to slow, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's eyes flew wide.

One attack was as fierce as could be. The other was so stealthy it raised goose bumps.

Their energies were opposites—he could tell that from the sound alone. But the Blood-Sword Demon Lord knew better than anyone what they had in common.

If I let even one strike through, it's over.

How many martial artists in this vast land could withstand the attacks coming at him now, even if the whole world were turned upside down?

The Fire King and the Bow Saint.

The Bow Saint and the Fire King.

They weren't merely relics of a distant past.

They had written their own legends then, and carried those legends into the present. In the distant future, countless storytellers would sing of their deeds and praise them.

That was how legends lasted. How giants were remembered forever.

And perhaps, here today, a new verse would be written in that legend.

Two great martial artists had felled the fiend known as the Blood-Sword Demon Lord on the open plain of the Great Snow Mountain, amid blood and snow.

But…

That will never happen.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord clenched his teeth. As the flow of time slowly returned, he pushed every ounce of strength and every sense he possessed to its limit and twisted his body.

He moved with an agility he doubted he could ever summon again in his life.

Slice!

A sudden, burning pain ran along his arm and the side of his neck.

The Bow Saint.

She had separated her beloved weapon, which had been shaped like a bow, into two curved swords. She had already passed him by.

With two flashes of those blades, swung stealthily yet swiftly as lightning, she had torn away part of his nape and the shoulder of his left arm.

But an attack that should have taken his life outright had done surprisingly little. Before the pain could fully register, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord felt an appalling heat rush at him from the side.

Fwoosh! Poom!

Hng…!

It all happened almost at once.

Jeok Cheongang's Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist swept fiercely past his flank.

That glancing blow alone melted away a fistful of flesh.

And the unbearable pain made the Blood-Sword Demon Lord suck in a breath and stop moving without realizing it.

But that was all.

At that moment, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord was cheering deep down because he had survived.

Even though the Bow Saint had taken one of his arms, and the heat from Jeok Cheongang's fist had melted part of his flank and reached his innards as well.

That's enough.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had something to fall back on. Injuries like these were bearable.

What mattered more than anything was that he hadn't fallen to the combined attack of the Fire King and the Bow Saint—and that, unlike them, who had already missed their perfect chance, he still had one move left.

I'll kill them. I swear it!

A decisive strike always left an opening.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord suppressed the pain surging through him and brought his sword down at Jeok Cheongang, who watched him with eyes wide.

No—more precisely, he tried to.

Before he could, someone moved with a desperate resolve equal to—or perhaps greater than—his own moments earlier.

Thuk!

A fierce, unexpected pain shot through him. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord staggered, then stared in disbelief at the dark blade buried deep in his ankle—and at the face of the man holding it.

Black Night King Sima Gong.

"You son of a—"

The moment he managed to force out a groan—

"I told you. Every last one of them died."

Poom! Krrrcrack!

At Jeok Cheongang's cold voice, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's vision flipped over.

The dark sky. The ground covered in blood and snow. The countless people fighting and killing one another across it.

Everything turned blindingly white, then red.

Flame Divine Palm.

Unlike Jeok Cheongang's cold voice, the dreadful heat melted flesh and broke bones as it sank deep into his body. Trapped by the excruciating pain, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord could do nothing.

But an unexpected stroke of luck awaited him—one even he hadn't foreseen.

KWA-BOOM! KWA-BOOM! Krrrcrack!

His body shot away like a cannonball, unable to withstand the tremendous force. It rolled and crashed along the ground before finally slamming into something.

"Well."

As the Blood-Sword Demon Lord spat blood mixed with bits of his innards, a voice drifted faintly into his ear.

"You've been badly hurt, Demon Lord."

Was he hearing things?

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord blinked weakly as he wondered. Then he realized the slope beneath his battered body was a hillside, and that the voice he'd just heard sounded uncannily familiar.

"Guh, hahahaha!"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord burst out laughing without meaning to.

Bloody phlegm bubbled in his throat, and every time his body shook with laughter, tremendous jolts of pain shot through his broken limbs. He didn't care in the least.

He laughed like a madman.

Like the happiest person in the world. Like someone who had been rescued at the very edge of death.

Trembling with joy, he stretched a bloodied hand toward his savior.

No—he gave his subordinate an order.

"Heal me. Right now."

The savior, the Grand Sorceress, gazed silently at the Blood-Sword Demon Lord. She slowly parted her lips to speak—

Shwaak!

A streak of light whistled through the air. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord's eyes flew wide.

Beyond the Grand Sorceress's shoulder, he saw a young man hauling himself up from where he had fallen. His eyes blazing, the young man brought his spearhead down.

There was not even a thread of internal energy in it. No trace of his usual strength or speed.

Jin Taekyung was squeezing out every last bit of strength he had left for a strike with all his might.

That crazy bastard…!

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord screamed soundlessly.

Clang!

An invisible barrier around the Grand Sorceress knocked away the silver-white spearhead.

It did so with astonishing ease, as if mocking the desperate hope behind the blow.

And then—

That was all.

Thud.

The spear shaft rolled from its owner's powerless hand.

In the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's eyes, still wide with shock, a figure slowly began to topple.

Thump.

The body finally crumpled.

Jin Taekyung lay in a wretched heap, glaring weakly at him. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord sucked in a breath without realizing it.

You stubborn bastard.

He'd already reached his limit, and still he'd waited for a chance to strike.

His persistence was so terrifying it inspired awe—or rather, sent a chill down the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's spine.

But…

That desperate struggle ends here.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord bared his bloodied teeth in a grin.

If he were his former self—or even just a flesh-and-blood human—those injuries would have killed him several times over.

But his body, strengthened to an extreme degree, had granted him a brief handful of moments. Those moments would change everyone's fate.

The Fire King and the Bow Saint, both rushing here with all their strength even now.

The tens of thousands of enemies and allies swinging their weapons amid the sea of corpses and blood.

And, most important of all, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's own life and death.

"It's time… to put an end to this damned battle."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord forced out the words, his breathing noticeably more labored. The Grand Sorceress nodded calmly.

"Of course."

At that moment—

Fwoosh.

A brilliant light spread from the Grand Sorceress’s fingertips.

A healing light, warm as the midday sun and clear as a pond deep in the mountains.

Ah.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s eyes closed without his meaning to.

For a moment, he let himself sink into the peace the light brought.

Then, after a moment that felt both brief and eternal, he opened his eyes.

He stared, unable to believe what he saw.

“What… is this?”

His body was still horribly mangled, not healed in the slightest.

And someone else, wrapped in the fading glow, was breathing more steadily than before.

No.

Jin Taekyung.

Chapter 1049

In that instant, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord's mind went blank save for a single thought.

Am I dreaming?

It was a perfectly natural question.

How could it not be?

The woman before him, the Grand Sorceress, was his ally.

They served the same master and shared the same goal.

That was why the Blood-Sword Demon Lord could hardly believe what he was seeing.

Not until the next moment, when the Grand Sorceress—who had been silently looking down at him—parted her tightly closed lips.

"Are you still dreaming?"

"…What?"

"This isn't a dream, Demon Lord. It's very much real."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared blankly at the Grand Sorceress, thinking about what her voice had just whispered into his ear.

Why was this happening?

As if to confirm that it was all real, agony throbbed through every inch of his body. He barely managed to force out the words.

"Your joke… has gone too far."

"A joke? I'm afraid I don't know what you mean."

The woman tilted her head as if she truly had no idea. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord clenched his teeth.

Rage surged from deep in his chest, and blood came welling up with it.

"Hurry. Cough. Hurry and heal me."

"You don't need to worry about that anymore."

Beneath her veil, her red lips curved softly.

The Grand Sorceress smiled at the Blood-Sword Demon Lord as he struggled for breath. Then she turned her head and added,

"The healing is already done."

She was telling the truth.

It was healing in the literal sense.

Not enough to restore someone completely, but enough to hold on to a consciousness slowly sinking into darkness.

Hoooo.

Taekyung's labored, wheezing breaths steadied. His deathly pale face and lips gradually regained their color.

As the warm radiance surrounding him faded away completely, the Grand Sorceress's slender fingers swept through the air.

Crack! Shhhhk!

The earth split open like a sealed box being forced apart.

At the same time, plant stems hidden deep beneath it surged up, coiling around the young man—Jin Taekyung—and lifting him into the air.

As if to show him to the intruders who were still rushing toward the hill at full speed.

When Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint saw Jin Taekyung bound like a hostage in the distance, they had no choice but to stop, though neither knew exactly what had happened.

"It's a little sad that my sincerity didn't get through, but what can you do? This is the only way."

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared blankly at the Grand Sorceress as she clicked her tongue softly. Only then did he finally understand.

This was no dream. No cruel prank.

"Why?"

The question held a multitude of meanings.

But the answer was brief and clear.

"Because that person wants it."

Her silver-white veil swayed.

The Grand Sorceress's eyes, faintly visible behind it, were devoid of emotion. She no longer looked at him as a subordinate would look at a superior.

Her calm voice, addressed to the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who had gone rigid as a statue, was no different.

"You've spent your whole life running wild. It's about time you got some rest, don't you think?"

Maybe it was because his senses were slowly growing dull even now.

Or maybe it was the shock of something he'd never expected.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord listened blankly to her voice echoing in his ears. Then a word slipped out.

"Bullshit."

His voice carried unmistakable exhaustion, but beneath it lay unshakable certainty.

He couldn't possibly be abandoned like this.

Even if his master had always thought of him as nothing more than a hunting dog, he couldn't throw him into the cauldron so pointlessly.

The old saying about cooking the hound after the hare is dead?

That only happened when the hunt was over.

But what was the state of the Lord of Heaven—of Dark Heaven—now?

The Western Heaven Demon Lord and the Southern Heaven Demon Empress had fallen. Then the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord and the North Heaven Demon Lord had fallen, too.

The four beasts he'd trusted most were gone.

The Central Plains martial world, rallied under the Murim Alliance's banner, was no mere hare. And the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who had survived alongside the Blood Lord, was more than a hunting dog.

The proof was that he had brought an army of tens of thousands all the way here under his command.

And that wasn't all.

He only had to reach out a little farther—just a little—and sweet victory would be his.

If only this damned body could recover.

With Jin Taekyung as a hostage, he could handle even the Fire King and the Bow Saint.

Dominion over Gansu lay before him—a bridgehead to victory across the realm.

And that person would abandon me now?

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord gave a hollow laugh.

Then he fixed his dark-red glare on the insolent woman trying to drive a wedge between him and his master with such absurd lies.

"Enough of your nonsense, woman. Do you think he doesn't know you betrayed him?"

There was no doubt about it.

The Grand Sorceress. That filthy traitor had ruined everything.

He was in this situation only because he hadn't recognized the tumor within his own ranks.

"Tell me, what did those deceitful bastards promise you? A grand estate? Mountains of gold and treasure? Or a peerlessly handsome man to satisfy those filthy desires of yours?"

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord spat out the words, his voice boiling over.

He had never been angrier.

Looking back, things had been suspicious from the beginning.

The Grand Sorceress had stopped him when he tried to enter the battle without hesitation. Because of that, the Black Ghosts, a core part of their fighting force, had been wiped out.

And even though she could use powerful spells the Blood-Sword Demon Lord himself hadn't known about, she had refused to help to the very end.

He'd been deceived.

Thoroughly toyed with.

The unbearable truth made him thrash about.

"You dare! Do you think a mere woman like you can kill me? Do you think you can ruin his grand plan with this little stunt?"

Crack. Thud.

From the crater left by their earlier collision, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord used every ounce of strength he had to haul himself upright.

He had lost an arm. The tendons in his leg had been severed, and his joints shattered. Even so, he still had the endurance and vitality that an ordinary person couldn't even imagine.

But consumed by fury, he had forgotten the most important fact.

He had survived injuries that should have killed him several times over because the Grand Sorceress's Magic still dwelled in his body.

"Can I kill you? Of course I can."

The Grand Sorceress watched impassively as the Blood-Sword Demon Lord crawled out of the crater toward her, then added,

"It would be very easy."

She was telling the truth.

She didn't even need to use Magic against the Blood-Sword Demon Lord in his current state.

All she had to do was dispel the body-enhancement Magic she'd placed on him.

If the Grand Sorceress decided to kill him right now, the fiend who had once made his mark on an entire age would meet a miserable death in moments.

But—

"You're right about one thing. Someone like me can't kill you."

"…What?"

Step.

Instead of answering his reflexive question, the Grand Sorceress took a light step backward.

Then, leaving him to struggle with what she meant, she spread both arms wide in an almost exaggerated gesture.

"Because there's only one person here who can kill you today."

At that very moment—

Shhhhk.

The plant stems, now thicker and stronger than iron chains, responded to their mistress's will.

Moving as if they had minds of their own, they carried the young man before her. His eyes were closed, and he appeared to be deep asleep.

Or rather, he *appeared* to be.

“Enough with the act. Why don’t you say something? Staying like that will only make me more wary of you.”

The next moment—

“Fuck. If you knew, you should’ve said so sooner.”

A curse burst from Jin Taekyung’s drool-slick lips. He opened his eyes a crack and fixed her with a sharp gaze.

I’d nearly lost consciousness.

No—maybe I really had, for a moment.

If someone hadn’t helped me when I least expected it, I’d probably be floundering in another long, endless nightmare by now.

Of course, even this situation felt like a dream.

…Hah.

I swallowed the laugh that threatened to escape me.

Right. This really wasn’t a dream.

The wind was still fierce, and the sky was dark.

The unceasing cries of battle were growing louder in my ears. Beneath the blades they swung, life and death crossed paths.

Aside from Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint, staring this way with their faces frozen, the scene below the hill was exactly as I’d last seen it.

Nothing had changed.

Nothing at all.

But things were different up here.

In this narrow space, everything had turned upside down.

Common sense. Expectations. Even friend and foe.

I’d listened to it all with my eyes closed, looking for all the world like I was dead.

Now I had no choice but to ask the woman before me—the Grand Mage—

“You… No. What exactly are you thinking?”

I still couldn’t understand.

Why had she healed me?

Why was she trying to finish off the Blood-Sword Demon Lord when she had the power to restore him to full health right now?

“Answer me. Come on.”

I glared at the Grand Mage, my eyes burning.

I wanted to break this Binding Magic right now and grab her by that pale throat. But I didn't have the strength for that.

All I could do was barely cling to my fading consciousness and move my limbs a little more freely than before.

That was all the healing power inside me was meant to do.

The Grand Mage spoke in a calm voice.

"That's a shame. If I were you, I wouldn't waste what little strength I had on questions like that."

"What?"

"Your question is wrong. This situation isn't happening because I chose it."

"…!"

The meaning of her words hit me, and my eyes widened.

"…You mean?"

"Exactly what you're thinking. A hunting dog does its job. It follows its master's orders."

The Grand Mage calmly answered, then pointed at the Blood-Sword Demon Lord and continued,

"And once its job is done, it's no longer needed."

Her words were so cold they sent a shiver down my spine.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had tried desperately to deny it. Anyone would have. But now, faced with a truth so shocking that anyone would be forced to deny it, he stared at her as though his soul had left his body.

"Why…?"

I wanted to ask the same thing.

Why? For what reason was the Lord of Heaven abandoning the Blood-Sword Demon Lord?

How could he throw away this crucial battle, one that might decide the course of this enormous war, without a second thought?

But the Grand Mage didn't answer.

Instead, she gazed at me with an inscrutable look and slowly parted her lips.

"You can't fall here. You have to get stronger."

"What… did you say?"

"Kill him. And then…"

Her blood-red lips moved beneath the veil.

"Get stronger."

Chapter 1050

When people faced a truth far beyond anything they'd expected, their reactions tended to fall into two camps.

They either fell into confusion, unable to understand it, or froze as they began to grasp its staggering weight.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord belonged to the first.

"What does that…?"

He muttered blankly, having forgotten even his pain.

Confronted with the crushing reality that the master he'd worshiped like a god had abandoned him, the fiend heard the Grand Sorceress's words ringing in his ears again and again.

You can't fall here. You have to get stronger than you are now.

No matter how many times the Blood-Sword Demon Lord turned over the Grand Sorceress's words about Jin Taekyung in his mind, he couldn't understand them.

Used up and thrown away?

Of course he felt betrayed.

But if the strong wanted blood, the weak had to bleed.

He had walked the Demonic Path all his life. He knew that law of the world as well as anyone.

He still didn't know why he was being discarded after devoting himself to the Lord of Heaven and Dark Heaven. But now that things had come this far, he had no choice but to accept it.

That was one thing. This was another.

Why? How? For what reason?

Why would the master he served pay such a high price to put the execution of his loyal hunting dog in an enemy's hands?

And not just any enemy. A brat who wasn't even thirty—the person who had thwarted Dark Heaven more often than anyone else in the world.

And…

Kill me, and get stronger?

What did his death, this one-sided execution, have to do with Jin Taekyung growing stronger?

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord couldn't begin to guess what the Grand Sorceress's final words meant. That was only natural.

There were limits to what he could imagine.

But at least one other person here knew the truth he couldn't.

"…You."

The young man’s lips had gone white, and the muscles of his face had stiffened.

He stared at the woman before him with vacant eyes, forgetting even to breathe. At last, he managed to force out the words.

“What are you even… saying?”

It wasn’t a question. It was a denial.

He didn’t want to believe this impossible reality, so he struggled to deny it.

The Grand Sorceress looked at the young man—Jin Taekyung—and her eyes curved into crescents.

“You already know, don’t you?”

“…!”

“Do I have to tell you what I mean, right here?”

The words turned his dreadful suspicion into certainty. Jin Taekyung felt his mind go blank.

Only one phrase remained.

Level Up.

Was this what it felt like when all the blood in your body turned cold?

For a moment, it seemed as though the whole world had stopped.

No—maybe I really had mistaken it for that.

Maybe I really would have believed it had, if not for my head burning like someone was pressing a hot iron to it while the rest of me stood frozen.

This… can’t be real.

I floundered in confusion.

Questions kept surfacing and vanishing. Reason and emotion lost their bearings and crashed into each other.

The shock was as great as—maybe greater than—what I’d felt when I realized this strange world called Murim wasn’t a game, but another reality.

Yet this was real.

I fought to suppress my shock and forced out a question.

“How? How is this possible?”

My voice came out hoarse and cracked, so unfamiliar it might have belonged to someone else.

The woman’s reply, by contrast, was calm.

“Who knows? Someone as insignificant as I am can’t know everything. But…”

The Grand Sorceress—or the Grand Mage.

She had gained power that didn't belong to this world. Now she stared straight at me, her eyes and voice so full of unwavering faith it could only be called fanaticism. The sight and sound made my senses reel.

"The Lord of Heaven is great. I am merely a servant who conveys His will and His words."

"The Lord of Heaven. The Lord of Heaven…"

I repeated that damned name like a man under a spell.

Ever since the day I'd taken my first steps in Murim, I'd heard it from countless people. And yet I'd never once encountered its true form.

The leader of Dark Heaven—or rather, their king and god. The absolute being who sought to defy heaven.

Him.

Only him.

He knew one of my most closely guarded secrets as plainly as if he were looking at the palm of his hand.

But that didn't answer my question.

Because I—Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan—had become someone else overnight.

"Were you watching me? From the beginning?"

"Watching you?"

Beneath her white veil, her red lips curved gently.

"Let's be honest. Just a few years ago, you weren't someone we needed to concern ourselves with. Everyone knows that."

"Then…"

"It's simple. We were looking down upon the world, and you shone on your own within it. Bright enough to see clearly, even from far away."

"…!"

"It was fascinating to watch the wastrel of a declining frontier martial family become a Hidden Dragon, then gain the Fire King as his dragon pearl and grow into a Divine Dragon. And to see how fast you grew."

An imugi that had cultivated itself for hundreds of years could become a dragon if it obtained a dragon pearl. But Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had been, at best, an earthworm in muddy water.

Yet the System had given me boundless opportunities to grow. People had supplied explanation after explanation without my having to make a single excuse.

Heaven-given martial talent.

The Heavenly Martial Physique, a body as perfect as could be.

And the teachings of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, a great martial artist.

That, they said, was how I'd reached my current strength.

So no one suspected a thing.

No—they *couldn't* have.

Even in this world, for all its primitive savagery, there were limits to what people considered possible.

But the Grand Mage was telling me now that someone outside their reach—at least, the Lord of Heaven—had been the exception.

And she had revealed something else I hadn't expected.

"We kept watching at His command. At last, we learned who the Chosen One was."

My eyes twitched before I could stop them.

"What… did you just say?"

"Why? Don't you like the name? I thought it was rather good."

I didn't answer.

I pressed my lips together and repeated what I'd heard in my head.

The Chosen One?

There was only one reason I'd asked her to repeat herself.

This wasn't the first time someone had called me that.

The first to call me the Chosen One was, even now, far off in the distance with her bowstring taut, aimed in this direction.

The Bow Saint.

A hero of the Great Faction War, who had protected the Nine Provinces from a hundred thousand members of the Demonic Cult.

A great martial artist who had always shone brilliantly, wherever she went, and was therefore called one of the Three Saints.

And the reason the Bow Saint had spent decades wandering the land, concealing her identity, was a letter left behind by one person.

…The Martial God.

Ten Kings. Three Saints.

Above them all stood the heaven that looked down upon everything—the universe, or perhaps Murim itself.

The greatest hero and martial artist of all time, with no equal before or since.

The Martial God had left the Bow Saint a letter.

He'd told her to find someone who might appear at any time, in any place.

The Chosen One—that is…

Me.

That made it even harder to understand.

I could accept that the Martial God had foreseen my arrival and left the Bow Saint a letter.

But why? How?

“Why are you—why is the Lord of Heaven—keeping me alive?”

I had stood in Dark Heaven’s way more than anyone else.

I’d been directly involved in the deaths of four Demon Lords and the Demon Empress, his closest subordinates and limbs. I’d caused him countless other losses, too.

From the Lord of Heaven’s perspective, I was someone he could kill a hundred times and still not be satisfied.

Yet the Grand Mage had said it plainly.

Her master didn’t want me to die here.

He wanted me to survive and grow stronger. Stronger than I was now.

I had to hear the answer.

If the Lord of Heaven wanted me alive, then my very existence would someday become a threat to everyone.

“Answer me. Now.”

The shock and trembling had passed.

All that remained was the reality before me and the cold resolve to face it.

I stared at the Grand Mage with icy eyes. Through her tightly woven white veil, I could make out the gleam of eyes burning with loyalty to their master.

At last, her red lips parted.

“No one in the world would dare presume to know His deeper purpose. But one thing is certain.”

She breathed out slowly.

The corner of her mouth lifted in unmistakable scorn.

“Even if you heard the whole truth, could someone like you resist?”

“…!”

“Let’s be honest with each other.”

As casually as she might throw off a cumbersome robe, the Grand Mage dropped her manners. Smiling, she went on.

“Do you think rain falls because people pray for it? No. The clouds gather, and it rains when the heavens will it. That’s the way of this world. Its natural order.”

Crack.

Her eyes flashed behind the veil. A thick vine crept up my body and tightened around my neck.

Slowly. And powerfully.

“If you want to die, I can kill you. But you have to survive, according to His will. You want to live, too. Don’t you?”

I couldn’t breathe.

My whole body was already bound. As the vine gradually squeezed my throat, I forced out the words.

“Then… kill me.”

“What?”

“Go on. Kill me.”

“…!”

The Grand Mage’s gaze wavered.

She’d heard the sincerity in my breathless voice and seen it in my eyes, which were steady despite my labored breathing.

“You…”

Her words trailed off, and the pressure on my neck eased. I looked at her and gave a short laugh.

“What? Can’t do it, you crazy bitch?”

Crack!

The vine tightened again, as hard as before.

Even so, I laughed aloud between gasps.

Yeah, right now I was unquestionably the weaker one.

But in this tug-of-war with our lives on the line, I was going to win.

If the Grand Mage was a crazy bitch, then I was a different kind of crazy bastard.

Now that it’s come to this, I can do it.

I smiled brightly at the Grand Mage, whose eyes had gone wide.

Then, with all the strength I had, I severed the heart meridians throughout my body.

Using the faint healing power she herself had given me.

Crunch!

Chapter 1051

"You…"

The moment the Grand Sorceress saw a smile spread across Jin Taekyung's face, which had been turning deathly pale, she instinctively realized how foolish a mistake she'd made.

Shit.

It was an irreparable blunder.

She had loosened the binding spell without thinking because his *Kill me if you can* had been so unmistakably sincere.

And Jin Taekyung had immediately seen her true intentions in that split-second mistake.

"What? Can't do it, you crazy bitch?"

"…!"

The Grand Sorceress bit her lip. He'd hit the mark.

A hunting dog could only tear out its target's throat when its master gave permission. She didn't yet have that authority, and her earlier bluster about the natural order had been exposed.

Of course, even so—

Nothing changes. Nothing at all.

The Grand Sorceress thought to herself, then poured her strength back into the Magic that had briefly faltered.

Crack!

The thick, sturdy vines squeezed Jin Taekyung's neck even tighter, as if they'd never loosened at all.

The gulf in strength between them, so stark in that moment, could not be bridged. Unlike him, with barely a trace of internal energy left, a tremendous force still lay coiled deep within the Grand Sorceress's body.

And that wasn't all.

With Jin Taekyung held hostage, even the Fire King and the Bow Saint couldn't risk a reckless move.

All she had to do now was make the young brat submit.

The Grand Sorceress was certain of it—until she saw the smile on his face, brighter than ever.

…He's smiling?

She couldn't understand what it meant. Or rather, she knew instinctively, but her mind refused to accept it.

There was only one thing Jin Taekyung could still do in his helpless state. And surely there wasn't a lunatic anywhere in the world who would choose suicide.

But—

Crunch!

There was.

That lunatic was right here, before her eyes.

Splatter! Splash!

In that instant, the Grand Sorceress's eyes opened wide without her meaning to.

Everything was red.

Through the blood sliding down her white veil, she saw Jin Taekyung trembling all over and coughing up blood.

"Th-This…"

A stunned gasp escaped her lips.

There was no doubt. He'd severed his own heart meridian.

Even a massive old tree, one that wouldn't easily fall to a lumberjack's axe, couldn't withstand a colony of ants boring through its bark and into its core.

For a Murim martial artist, severing the heart meridian meant death. Agonizing, but swift.

Why would he go this far?

Frozen for an instant, the Grand Sorceress stared at Jin Taekyung in utter shock.

She'd told him only half the truth. It was nowhere near enough to make him certain of anything—just enough to give him a vague suspicion.

Yet how many people under heaven would throw away their lives without hesitation because they suspected their mere existence threatened someone?

None. Surely none.

The strongest desire humans had was the desire to live. Even someone who made such a choice would need time to doubt, to steel themselves, before carrying it out.

But Jin Taekyung had done it without the slightest hesitation or fear.

Even smiling brightly as he did.

His eyes were already dimming, yet there was no wavering in them. He was certain he'd chosen the right path.

And as she looked at him, the Grand Sorceress finally understood her gravest mistake.

The Chosen One.

Letting him read her intentions earlier was nothing compared to this. She should have understood what those five characters meant. She should have guessed why her great master had searched so long for the young man before her, why he'd ordered his loyal servants to watch his every move.

Jin Taekyung was that kind of person.

He could curse and still know humanity and justice. He could spit and still pursue the chivalrous path. He might walk along the edge of the road, but he would never stray from the right one.

A chivalrous hero who led the way before everyone—and a lunatic beyond anyone's imagination.

That was why he was the Chosen One.

Crack!

The Grand Sorceress clenched her teeth.

There was no more time to hesitate, no choice left to make.

Her master had already waited far too long. If Jin Taekyung died here today, he would have to wait again, with no end in sight.

I have to save him. Whatever it takes!

As time seemed to slow, the Grand Sorceress reached out, more desperate and frantic than ever.

Swooooooosh!

Immense power surged around her slender frame.

Driven not by the will to kill, but by the will to keep him alive, the energy surrounding her heart pulsed fiercely. The energy dormant in the air answered it, then burst into light and swallowed everything around them.

Flash! Fwoom!

The swelling radiance swept over the hill.

No—it spread until it covered the entire hill.

Its dazzling brilliance bleached the eyes of the Bow Saint and Jeok Cheongang as they raced toward them, having realized something had happened to Jin Taekyung, who was being held hostage. It forced the eyes shut of the fiend, still writhing like an insect as he clung to life.

Even the Grand Sorceress herself, who had summoned that radiance.

What happened?

Her vision lost in the glare, she bit her lip.

When a pile of rocks collapses, it kicks up dust. But when a great mountain crumbles, it causes an earthquake.

A Supreme Peak master who had severed his own heart meridian had suffered an injury not even a Great Firmament Immortal could heal.

She'd unleashed the greatest healing power she could, but there was nothing she could guarantee. And the radiance that had erupted more fiercely than ever showed no sign of fading.

No—at that moment, it seemed to flash even brighter.

Like a blade shining all the more beneath the sun.

"…!"

Just as the Grand Sorceress's eyes widened when she realized something—

Shwaaak!

A chillingly low, razor-sharp whistle tore through the air. A silver-white spearhead, more than worthy of the name White Flame, ripped through space.

From beyond the dazzling light came someone's quiet voice.

"Got you."

Thud!

My stomach's churning.

My head's spinning, and my vision is blurry.

Maybe that's why I still can't tell whether this is a dream or reality.

If it's neither...

Hell? No, heaven?

Everything around me is so white I can barely open my eyes. Unless some enterprising Yama[3716] has installed ridiculously powerful LED bulbs throughout hell to improve conditions for its prisoners, this has to be heaven.

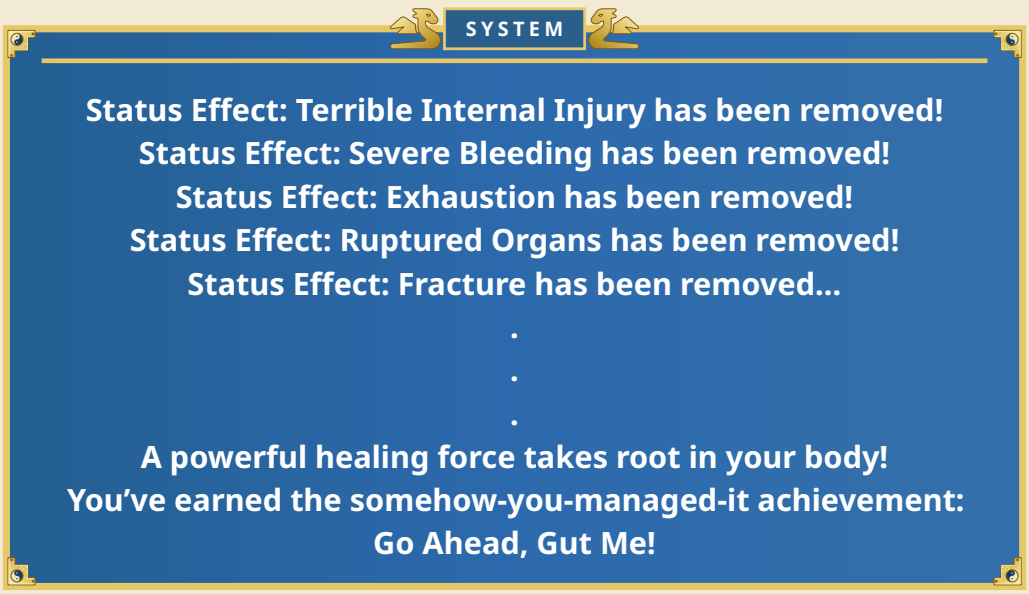
But—

Ding. Ding. Diiiing!

Clear chimes ring in my ears like an echo returning from far away. They tell me enough.

This is reality. I'm alive.

I've won again at this insane gambling table, where I put up the money I got for selling my life.



[3716] Yama is the Buddhist ruler and judge of the underworld.

Translucent holographic windows appear one after another in midair.

Along with them, my blurry vision cleared as if it had never been blurred. My breathing steadied, and my senses sharpened, letting me feel and take in everything within ten or so *jang*[3717].

Light. Air. Wind. Even formless things, like the thick stench of blood.

And the living beings breathing amid it all, with the same vitality as me.

Now it was time to collect my winnings from the other side of the bet.

Come.

I whisper the command inwardly and put my will behind it.

I send it toward a cold blade with no life of its own, though it has extinguished countless lives. Toward my beloved weapon, lying alone on the ground far from my hand.

Shwaaak!

It all happens almost at once, and I murmur,

“Got you.”

At that moment—

Thud!

With the sound of bone and flesh bursting, the thick vines binding my entire body loosen.

Now.

I don’t even need to draw on my internal energy. I pour into my limbs a strength beyond anything the word *superhuman* can describe, and let it loose.

Crack!

The vines split, then burst apart. They snap into pieces under that monstrous force, and I’m free.

I reach out toward White Flame as it shoots toward me like a streak of light.

Tap.

That cool touch is more familiar than anything.

But the blood spattered across the silver-white spearhead is still warm, and the scream that erupts nearby is agonized.

“Aaaah!”

On a battlefield where I can’t see, what could give me a better bearing than a scream?

Following the sharp cry through the lingering radiance, I take one long step.

Bang!

Compressed air explodes beneath my driving foot. The layers of light before me break apart, and the three *jang*[3718] between us vanish in an instant.

[3717] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3718] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

And then…

Shaaak!

At the end of the spear's downward-slashing arc, there was someone who owed me my stake. I could feel exactly where she was, even without seeing her.

Right then—

Swish. Slice!

Dark red blood sprays with a cold cutting sound.

But there's already no one in the spot where she screamed a moment ago.

Fast.

No. *Fast* doesn't begin to describe it.

Any Murim martial artist who saw that movement would call it Shifting Form and Position, a technique only a Supreme Peak master could use.

But no matter what anyone else in this world thought, I was the one exception.

Blink…!

A Magic spell that made you disappear in an instant, like the literal blink of an eye—a short-range teleport.

In a Grand Mage's hands, it works even faster than Shifting Form and Position. It's an incredible way to evade an attack—but that's all it is.

Three steps from my left. Five jang.[3719]

I know Blink's limits better than anyone under heaven.

Crack.

And I'm a superhuman with the strength and senses to catch up with it, despite its limited range.

Boom!

One step.

I cross that distance in an instant and smile brightly at the Grand Mage, frozen with her eyes wide.

"See you again?"

Shing!

[3719] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 1052

“See you again?”

At the sound of his low voice, Jin Taekyung was suddenly right in front of her. The Grand Sorceress felt the blood in her body turn cold.

How?

Calling him fast didn’t begin to explain it. His speed was beyond anything she’d expected.

And as though he’d known exactly where she would be, the silver spearhead came slashing down toward her body.

Whoosh!

The air split. No—it shattered.

Space warped around the Force coiling along the spearhead. Faced with that terrifying sight, the Grand Sorceress felt a fear greater than any she had known and cried out in her mind.

Mighty power of protection!

Vwoom.

In the slowed world, the energy gathered around her heart began to boil.

Layer upon layer of translucent shields rose around her, blocking the spearhead.

Boom! Crash!

The ground shook as if an earthquake had struck.

But all the Grand Sorceress’s attention was fixed on the sight before her.

The spearhead smashed through most of the dozens of layered shields before finally stopping—just barely.

I blocked it.

A shiver ran up her spine. Only then did she release the breath she’d been holding.

Before relief could settle in, she saw Jin Taekyung smiling faintly, though the attack he’d staked everything on had failed. Suddenly, she realized what she’d forgotten.

Some very important—and very dangerous—people.

But on a battlefield, realizations always came a moment too late.

Whoosh!

A vast streak of light hurtled across the space between them.

Beyond the dazzling glare filling her vision, she made out two figures. The Grand Sorceress screamed without a sound.

The Bow Saint…!

Boom!

An enormous blast rang out, and the swelling light swallowed the entire hill.

At the last moment, it all happened almost at once.

I'd backed away, anticipating the shock of the tremendous collision.

Far away, the Force arrow had left the bowstring and come hurtling toward us. At last, it struck the shield.

And then—

Fwoom!

The distant flash of light swelled, blocking everyone's view and swallowing the Grand Sorceress's figure, which had been hidden behind the crumbling shield.

Rumble…!

The earth shook. Light burst forth in an instant, tearing through the darkness and devouring everything.

A wave of power beyond words.

Hngh…!

I sucked in a breath and curled up as tightly as I could. A gale whipped past me like a blade, slashing through the air.

The moment lasted only an instant, but it felt like an eternity. When it passed, I could finally hear again.

A familiar voice reached my muffled ears.

"Are you all right?"

I let out the breath I'd been holding and raised my head.

Beyond the fading light, I saw a white robe torn to shreds, blood scattered everywhere, and limbs severed from a body.

They were slender and white—the limbs clearly belonged to a woman.

"It's over. All of it."

"…Ah."

The Grand Mage was dead.

The moment that sank in, all the strength drained from my body.

My mental strength had been at its limit for a long time. Exhaustion washed over me, and my vision blurred.

Grab.

A strong hand caught me as I swayed.

Jeok Cheongang hauled me upright, and a laugh escaped me.

"Sorry, Old Master."

"For what?"

"Seven and a half minutes. That ran out ages ago."

Jeok Cheongang laughed with me.

“Still a hundred years too soon. Can’t you tell, seeing that damned bastard run all the way over here?”

He was covered in blood, whatever he said. With a perfectly straight face, he pointed to an old fiend who had survived like a cockroach.

Of course, there was another reason the Blood-Sword Demon Lord had survived the blast.

“You went a long way while I was gone. Recklessly far, too.”

So Gyo—or rather, the Bow Saint—looked at me with her usual calm gaze and spoke.

She must have crossed half the land without a moment’s rest, yet her aura was still as sharp as a blade.

I knew better than anyone why the Bow Saint, despite the crushing fatigue she must have felt, was keeping up this front. I also knew why she had gone out of her way to protect the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

“But the rest will have to wait. There’s still a problem to deal with.”

She was right. The Grand Mage was dead, but the bloody battle below the hill continued.

And that wasn’t the only problem she meant.

“So this is how it’s come to pass.”

Cold killing intent edged her words. At her feet, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord lay breathing hard. He struggled to speak.

“Fine. Anything… I’ll tell you anything.”

Anything, huh?

I turned the word over in my mind as I staggered toward him and raised White Flame.

Shing.

I aimed the spearhead at him instead of answering.

Faced with its icy gleam, the Blood-Sword Demon Lord’s voice grew louder. He was still trying to sound calm.

“There was a traitor among you!”

The fiend who had radiated such terrifying power was nowhere to be seen.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord sprawled before me now was little more than a beggar, ruined at the end of a lifetime steeped in brutality.

Abandoned by his master. Betrayed by his allies. Now begging for his life by selling information to the very enemy he’d tried to kill.

“Are you afraid?”

“…What?”

“Can things like you feel fear?”

I looked down at his wide, bloodshot eyes and spoke softly.

“There’s no deal.”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord was already a discarded dog.

Perhaps his fate had been sealed long ago: to be discarded once he’d outlived his usefulness.

I didn’t know the exact reason, but this was the outcome the Lord of Heaven had intended. No master would lavish care on a hunting dog he planned to cast aside without mercy.

So I had no reason to listen to the dog. Least of all when he wanted to talk about the traitors whose identities had begun to come to light today.

“Black Night King Sima Gong. The Roaring Fury Swordsman Song Il. And the Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom.”

“…!”

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord said nothing, but his eyes shook violently.

That was enough to turn a near-certainty into certainty.

“You already… knew?”

He barely managed to force the words out.

I nodded at his dazed face.

“To a certain extent.”

“B-But then why?”

“If you’re asking why… I don’t know.”

I raised the spearhead, exhaustion bearing down on me.

And I thought about why I’d made it this far, despite suspecting there were traitors among us. Why I’d fought for my life in this impossible situation and refused to give up.

Maybe it was because…

“I wanted to believe a little longer.”

“…!”

“You can’t win without believing in them. That’s why I came all this way like a fucking idiot.”

Yeah.

That was what made victory possible.

The difference between Dark Heaven and us.

Between the Lord of Heaven and me.

I’d already seen what came of that slender thread of faith and hope. More precisely, of the faith that began with one person.

Sama Pyo.

Quiet and gloomy, but he’d never once betrayed my trust.

A comrade who had never been the first to step back, no matter how desperate things got. We'd fought back to back and laughed together, covered in each other's blood.

No. A friend.

If it weren't for him, I wouldn't have been able to place even this little faith in them.

Not long ago, Jeok Cheongang had asked what I would do if Sama Pyo and Taishan turned out to have betrayed us.

I hadn't answered.

Even as I walked down the Great Snow Mountain with Sama Pyo, I'd asked myself the same question. But I couldn't bring myself to answer it.

I wouldn't be able to kill them.

All I could do was believe. More desperately than anyone.

And I wasn't the only one who'd put faith in the traitors.

A Junior Brother in his two Senior Brothers.[3720] *A son in his father.*

In the end, their faith was rewarded.

It moved the traitors' hearts and finally turned the tide of battle.

I'd seen it myself.

The Taeeul Merciless Sword and the Roaring Fury Swordsman throwing themselves toward the Hell Fire. Sima Gong facing the Blood-Sword Demon Lord in Jeok Cheongang's place.

Of course, they wouldn't be forgiven for their crimes.

At least, I had no right to forgive them. Neither did Jeok Cheongang or the Bow Saint.

But I would remember that, when it mattered most, the traitors had upheld at least the smallest measure of honor.

Unlike the discarded hunting dog, who would soon be forgotten by its master.

"That's why we're different. You and us."

My voice was quiet, but clear. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord stared at me, the tiny blood vessels in his eyes burst.

"Jin Taekyung!"

His cry came out as though he were coughing up blood.

Thuk.

The spearhead sank into his chest as smoothly as a blade through tofu, swallowing the rest of his words.

No—the last faint trace of life left in him.

Ding.

A clear chime rang in my ears.

[3720] In a martial sect, Senior Brother and Junior Brother indicate relative seniority among disciples, not necessarily a family relationship.

At the same time, an energy as refreshing as mountain-stream water swept through me, once again filling my body with new strength.

Unlike the man who had died with a silver-white spearhead through his chest.

And just as the woman who had died moments before, too horribly to leave her body in one piece, had wanted.

I mustn't fall here? I have to get stronger than I am now?

Feeling the crushing mental exhaustion weighing on my body, I turned to look toward the last trace of the Grand Mage, left behind where the Force arrow had swept through.

Don't worry. I'll make sure of it.

I didn't know what the Lord of Heaven wanted.

But one thing was clear.

I had to keep going. To keep moving forward, I had to grow stronger.

Strong enough to far exceed the Lord of Heaven's expectations. Strong enough to make him regret this choice someday.

Whatever gets in my way, I'll just smash it to pieces.

That was how I'd lived until now, and how I'd live from here on.

With that thought, I turned my unsteady body around.

Or I tried to.

Then I saw a slender arm and leg lying in a pool of blood, each severed from her body. Their cut ends were sharp and clean.

No.

"…!"

Not until I spotted the traces of Teleport.

Chapter 1053

The shock was so great that the world seemed to stop. For an instant, Jin Taekyung forgot to breathe.

At the sight of this guess flashing through his mind—a guess he didn't want to believe—a corner of his chest throbbed as if he'd been stabbed.

"What happened…?"

"Wait. Just a moment."

Jin Taekyung had gone still as a statue. Jeok Cheongang seemed to realize something and raised a hand, cutting off the Bow Saint's question.

Of course he knew every moment counted. A fierce battle was still raging below the hill.

But by now, he and his young Disciple understood each other with a glance. They hardly needed even that. The old Master was certain Taekyung had a reason for stopping, and he was right.

Step. Step.

Though he staggered with exhaustion, Taekyung walked on as if entranced.

The scene ahead drew closer, its details coming into sharp focus.

Shreds of a white robe fluttered in a breeze from somewhere. Nearby lay a small pool of blood.

They were the last traces of someone who had been there. Taekyung reached out with a trembling hand and touched the largest of them.

A woman's arm and leg, slender and so pale that the veins showed through her skin.

Even now, dark red blood was gushing from their cross sections. They were cut with unbelievable precision, smooth and sharp.

As if the limbs hadn't been cut off, but *separated*.

This… definitely wasn't a wound caused by Force.

At last, faced with the truth, Taekyung let out the breath he'd been holding.

There was no mistaking it. He belonged to two worlds, after all. He was both a Murim martial artist and a Hunter.

That was why he could recognize the marks on the arm and leg, each separated from her body, better than anyone.

"Teleport…"

The word escaped his lips before he knew it. Jeok Cheongang, now beside him, asked with a rigid face, "Tell me it isn't what this old man thinks."

Taekyung didn't answer.

But Jeok Cheongang already knew what his silence meant.

"That bizarre sorcery again. No—Magic?"

Yes. Magic. That damn Magic.

Overcome by a helplessness he couldn't put into words, Taekyung nodded. Jeok Cheongang's eyes flashed.

He was already worn down by injuries, both large and small, and by exhaustion. Yet there wasn't a trace of resignation in those eyes, where flames seemed to pour forth.

"This isn't the time. Before it's too late, we need to—"

"It's already too late."

"What?"

Taekyung clenched his teeth.

Teleport.

A spatial travel spell notorious for its difficulty, even among the countless kinds of Magic.

Unlike Blink, which was limited to short distances, Teleport could cover dozens[3721] or even hundreds of kilometers[3722] at once, depending on the mage's Grade and how much mana they possessed.

Not hundreds of *jang*.[3723] Hundreds of kilometers.

Then how far could Grand Mages, who had reached the limits of Magic, go?

If… every condition were perfect, maybe they could cross half the continent.

Taekyung didn't know the exact distance. What mattered was that the Grand Mage—a big catch—had already torn through the net and fled far away.

Exhaustion pressed even more heavily on him as he spoke.

"She's beyond our range. By now, she must be at least dozens of *ri*[3724] away."

"What do you mean…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened, but he swallowed the rest.

Traveling dozens of *ri*[3725] in the blink of an eye was beyond anything reason could account for. Yet he already knew such things were possible. He had seen them with his own eyes.

The inexplicable phenomena tied to Dark Heaven. The ghostly power called Magic, which defied both words and common sense.

"Goddamn it!"

Boom!

Jeok Cheongang stamped his foot in fury, and cracks spread across the ground like a spiderweb.

Through the crash came the Bow Saint's low voice.

[3721] One dozen kilometers is 12 km, about 7.5 mi.

[3722] 100 km is about 62 mi.

[3723] A Korean *jang* is approximately 3.03 m, or 9.94 ft.

[3724] A Korean *ri* is approximately 393 m, or 0.244 mi.

[3725] A Korean *ri* is approximately 393 m, or 0.244 mi.

“Even if you’re right, she’s lost an arm and a leg. Her life must be in danger. Is there no chance she died?”

Taekyung shook his head weakly.

“I don’t know. But I doubt it.”

“Why?”

“There must be mages there, too—or sorcerers, as they call them here.”

“Then…”

“Yes. She returned to her allies. We can’t guess where that is, but the Grand Sorceress would have known exactly.”

Jin Taekyung added, staring at the arm and leg submerged in the pool of blood,

“She must have believed she could survive. Otherwise, she wouldn’t have taken a gamble like this.”

Teleport was a difficult spell for long-distance travel. The coordinates of both the starting point and the destination had to be exact, without the slightest error. It demanded more preparation than any other spell.

Even in the modern world, the high-ranking mages who specialized in Teleport and made their living from it were no exception. If anything, knowing the danger made them more careful.

If even the slightest figure went wrong as the spell took effect, they could die instantly, fused with a rock or a tree.

Or…

Their limbs could be separated.

The thought passed silently through Taekyung’s mind. He looked down at the flesh left behind. It was no longer a sign that someone had died.

It was proof that the Grand Mage had gambled her life—and succeeded.

I made a mistake. I should’ve finished her off myself. Made absolutely sure.

He hadn’t expected her to attempt Teleport in the middle of that frantic struggle, with her starting position changing every moment. Much less for the spell to succeed under such unstable conditions.

But regret always arrived a step too late. Taekyung still had to walk the path before him.

The narrow, treacherous path that now seemed clearer and closer—and yet, for some reason, more distant and beyond reach.

Toward the being waiting at its end.

Lord of Heaven.

The title lingered on the tip of his tongue, never spoken. Taekyung turned it over in his mind, bitter as bear gall.

Who was he?

Why was he staining the world with blood and beckoning to Taekyung from behind that dark red curtain?

And what connection did he have to the other being who had haunted Taekyung's thoughts for so long?

The Demon King. Asmodeus.

Ruler of the Demon Realm. Lord of demons.

An invader who'd torn through the boundaries between dimensions with his overwhelming power, shattered every convention and civilization, and driven billions of people to terror and death.

Yet in the end, he had fallen at the hands of one human. Now he would be remembered forever as part of history.

That's right. He's dead. I know he is.

Then why?

Why couldn't Taekyung get that accursed being out of his head?

Crack.

He bit his lip until it bled.

Over the years he'd spent moving between the modern world and Murim, he'd seen countless lights and shadows. But the darkness cast by *Dark Heaven* was deeper than any of them. The Lord of Heaven stood at the center of it all, and Taekyung could scarcely deny his existence any longer.

First came all those strange phenomena that overturned everything he knew. Now, Magic.

What the hell is waiting at the end of this?

Taekyung turned his head toward somewhere far to the west.

The Demon King and the Lord of Heaven.

The Lord of Heaven and the Demon King.

He didn't know whether they'd originally been one being or two entirely different people. The greatest enemy of his life was somewhere beyond the western horizon.

Beckoning to the Chosen One.

For a reason no one else yet knew.

Even knowing that, Taekyung had to keep walking the path he had chosen. Quietly, desperately, with everything he had.

Splash.

He rose, his foot landing in the pool of blood, and forced himself to take a step.

The battle wasn't over. Countless enemies were still killing and dying like soulless puppets. He headed toward them to finish it.

"Can you hold on?"

"No."

His Master was watching him with concern. Taekyung looked ready to collapse, but he gave him a faint smile.

"But I have to. Somehow."

In the past and in the present, that was what he had always done.

Whoosh!

Taekyung charged toward the enemy without hesitation, shoulder to shoulder with his old Master. Force arrows were already streaking through the air above them.

And the three of them weren't the only ones racing toward the battlefield to end this vast, horrific fight.

Bwooo!

A horn sounded without warning. Those who turned toward it saw a pale cloud of dust sweeping across the vast range of the Great Snow Mountain toward the battlefield.

At the head of thousands of men and horses, a group waved a torn banner and shouted as if coughing up blood.

"Subdue the Demons! Destroy Heaven!"

Hundreds of voices, charged with pure internal energy, burst through the air. The banner billowed in the wind as it advanced with them.

Neither the blood spattered across its white cloth nor the pieces torn from it could erase what it stood for.

It was their pride.

Long ago, it had also been a line of verse written by an old man called the Poet Sage,[3726] praising the Daoists who lived in the remote mountain valleys.

"*With one long sword to guard the body, one would seek support from Kongtong.*"

Jeok Cheongang's voice scattered on the wind. Then the Bow Saint parted her tightly closed lips.

"If you would defend yourself with a single long sword, turn to Kongtong."

And at that moment—

Rrrrrumble!

In less than two shichen,[3727] this brutal battle had swallowed more than ten thousand lives.

Now the scales that would decide its outcome tipped completely.

No—they broke.

Just as some unknown person, somewhere thousands of *ri*[3728] away, had intended when they prepared the stage for this day.

[3726] The Poet Sage is an honorific for Du Fu, a Tang-dynasty poet.

[3727] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[3728] A Korean *ri* is approximately 393 m, or 0.244 mi.

Chapter 1054

“Awaken.”

Nothing more was needed.

The brief whisper roused her mind as it sank beneath the surface of sleep and took hold of her thoughts. Her eyelids, shut tight and motionless until now, opened.

“Ah.”

A short gasp escaped her.

At last conscious again, the Grand Sorceress looked at the pitch-black darkness pressing in from every side and understood.

The gamble she had taken in her final moments, risking her life, had succeeded.

It was also why she was still alive despite the wound that should have killed her.

“Heaven above and earth below, all demons bow in reverence!”

The Grand Sorceress cried out the eight characters of the sacred words engraved upon her soul, then hurriedly prostrated herself before the deep darkness.

First she dropped to both knees, then placed both arms on the ground. Finally, she struck her forehead against the stone hard enough to make it ring.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

Blood drops fell onto the cold stone floor as pain throbbed through her forehead, but the Grand Sorceress paid them no mind.

She could prostrate herself like this—and had recovered the arm and leg torn away when she was swept into unstable space—only through the grace of one being.

“This foolish and lowly servant presents herself before the great Lord of Heaven.”

At the reverence in the Grand Sorceress’s voice, the darkness surrounding her rippled slowly.

“Speak. Tell me everything you saw and heard.”

The brief command echoed inside her mind.

But the Grand Sorceress knew better than anyone that her master wasn’t asking who had won the battle.

His attention was fixed on one person alone.

“I sought to carry out the Lord of Heaven’s command, even at the cost of my life.”

Not daring to raise her face, the Grand Sorceress continued.

She told him roughly how many of their allies Jin Taekyung had killed, how many Black Ghosts had fallen in the process, and how the battle had unfolded from beginning to end.

“And so, shameful as it is, I had no choice but to flee in haste. Please, kill me.”

When she had finished, the Grand Sorceress quietly bit her lip.

She had done everything she could, but not all of it had gone perfectly according to plan.

Then, as she waited in fear, his voice sounded in her mind again.

“You did not see the Blood-Sword’s life taken?”

“…No. Nor did I foresee that the two Daoists of the Zhongnan Sect and Sima Gong would betray us again. Even if I had ten mouths, I would have no excuse.”

There was the Black Night King Sima Gong, who had joined forces with the Blood-Sword Demon Lord.

Then there were the Roaring Fury Swordsman Song Il and the Taeeul Merciless Sword Hwangbo Eom, whom Sima Gong had drawn in.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who had recruited the traitors starting with the Black Night King, had known nothing of it. Under the original plan, they should all have been dead by now—killed by Jin Taekyung before the real battle even began.

“But things went wrong somewhere I never expected, even before that.”

“What was it?”

“Kongtong.”

The Kongtong Sect.

They were to be the first supporting players on the stage the Grand Sorceress had prepared.

The Kongtong Sect survivors who had fled Dunhuang were supposed to join their allies in the rear and give a detailed account of everything they had seen and heard.

Dark Heaven’s overwhelming forces. The strange power called Magic.

And, finally, the crucial seed of suspicion that would expose the traitors. That was what the Grand Sorceress had intended to plant.

“So I let word of the traitors reach their ears. Then I let them go, pretending I couldn’t find them.”

She hadn’t failed to catch them.

She had let them go. Deliberately.

It was an audacious claim to make about the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, but the Grand Sorceress remained certain of it. Had she and the mages under her command joined the pursuit intent on killing, the Kongtong Sect would have been wiped out in Dunhuang.

But she had made no effort to capture and kill them.

Unlike the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, her goal wasn’t victory.

The separate order she had received from the Lord of Heaven concerned only Jin Taekyung’s survival and growth.

That was why some of the Kongtong Sect had been allowed to survive.

When she heard that their survivors, including the Sect Leader, had shaken off the relentless pursuit and escaped the encirclement, the Grand Sorceress had smothered a laugh to keep the Blood-Sword Demon Lord from noticing. She had already been thinking of what would come next.

The survivors would return and reveal the truth. Jin Taekyung would execute the handful of traitors, become a new rallying point for Dark Heaven's enemies, and lead them to a sweeping victory.

A safe and perfect plan.

But…

"Some of the survivors who knew the truth, including the Kongtong Sect's Sect Leader, vanished without a trace."

The darkness rippled sharply.

"Vanished without a trace?"

"Yes. Forgive me, but even with the power of the sorcery you granted this servant, I could not find them. At some point, they disappeared to a place I cannot even guess."

The first unexpected crack had appeared, but even the Grand Sorceress could not follow their trail.

Time passed. The real battle began. More cracks appeared, one after another.

For some reason, the traitors had chosen the foolish path again, even with the battle turning against them.

Jin Taekyung had severed his own heart meridian and gambled his life.

And the arrival of the Fire King and the Bow Saint had put the Grand Sorceress herself in danger.

"Please punish this lowly servant for failing to carry out your heavenly command."

She had achieved her immediate objective, but only that.

The Grand Sorceress lowered her head further and waited for her master's fury to shake heaven and earth.

But contrary to her fears, the mind-voice that echoed from deep within her a moment later, as if resonating, was as emotionless as ever.

"Raise your head."

The Grand Sorceress obeyed as if entranced. Beyond the closely woven veil over her face, the darkness writhed as though alive.

It was deeper and denser than she had ever seen it in the past several decades.

"Can you see it? Can you feel it?"

The Grand Sorceress didn't answer.

No—she couldn't.

Her pupils, which had rolled back until their whites showed at the sight of the darkness, were already turning black.

"I can see it. I can feel it. Everything hidden inside you. Clearly."

Whoosh.

The darkness that had completely consumed her retinas didn't stop there. It continued to spread.

Faster. Deeper.

It took hold of its loyal servant's mind as her slender body trembled and her reason slipped away. It swept through her thoughts and shook her spirit before returning to its master.

As if nothing had happened.

Thump.

"Ah—hah. Hah!"

The moment the darkness left her eyes and their focus returned, the Grand Sorceress collapsed like a puppet with its strings cut, gasping for breath.

"L-Lord of Heaven."

Her voice quivered. Her eyes were full of fear.

She knew instinctively what had happened.

The Lord of Heaven had just looked through every one of her thoughts and memories.

At the same time, an awe so intense it raised goose bumps drove out her fleeting fear and enveloped her whole body.

That power…

Remembering the power that had seeped into her body and seized her soul, the Grand Sorceress shuddered.

She knew it had been only a tiny fragment of his power. That made her wonder and shock all the greater.

Just how far can his power reach?

Even a thousand-year-old tree could never touch the clouds.

But the Lord of Heaven was different.

From the moment she had first met him, he had been the absolute ruler, beyond compare. And day by day, he had grown stronger to a degree that made the very word *limit* meaningless.

The change astonished even the Grand Sorceress, one of his closest confidants.

And she already had an idea where this unbelievable change had begun.

Jin Taekyung. No—the Chosen One.

She was certain of it.

A little more than two years ago, when bloodshed swept through Shanxi Province and the epithet Hidden Dragon became known throughout the land, her master had begun to change as well.

He started waking more often from deep slumbers that had lasted nearly a year at their shortest and as long as ten years. Each time, the Grand Sorceress could feel that the Lord of Heaven had grown stronger.

Even here, today.

But what could that possibly have to do with—?

It was a natural question.

But the next moment, a thunderous echo shook her mind, turning her thoughts blank.

"It is not your place to question anything."

"…!"

"Do not forget what your master wants. Do not forget what you must do."

The Lord of Heaven's voice seemed to pierce her soul. The Grand Sorceress realized she had momentarily forgotten something.

That the being before her was an absolute ruler, transcending everything.

To serve and worship him as her master, she could permit herself no questions or doubts.

"Please, please kill this irreverent servant!"

The Grand Sorceress cried out as if she were coughing up blood.

Pressed so close to the cold stone floor she seemed ready to become part of it, she reaffirmed her fanatical loyalty and praised her master.

She went on until her voice, once as clear and calm as a silver bell, grew hoarse and cracked.

Until her master finally issued his command to the lowly servant who had dared, even for an instant, to harbor a question.

"That is enough."

Rustle.

The darkness rippled gently and wrapped around the Grand Sorceress, as though caressing her.

"Nothing of the sort will ever happen. Your master knows that, unlike the Blood-Sword, that foolish hunting dog, your loyalty is steadfast and pure."

"Lord of Heaven…!"

"Go to the place that awaits you. Join forces there with another of your master's loyal servants and complete a new mission. The great plan is now truly close to completion."

Her master's trust came through more clearly than ever. Overcome, the Grand Sorceress began to weep.

“I will risk my life to fulfill the mission entrusted to me.”

“I believe you. Just as I always have.”

As his quiet voice echoed in her mind, some of the darkness wrapped around the Grand Sorceress sank deep into her body.

No—it seeped into her as if they had always been one.

Whoosh.

The Grand Sorceress shuddered as an unprecedented energy surged from deep within her.

She could sense what the immense new power her master had given her wanted at that very moment—and where it was leading her.

Qinghai.

At that instant—

Whoom!

A brilliant white flash suddenly swelled and burst outward, engulfing her slender body.

Pop.

It all happened in an instant, and ended in an instant.

The Grand Sorceress vanished without a trace. Alone in that pitch-black space, the absolute being murmured quietly.

“Time is passing.”

As the darkness slowly dispersed, an unidentified green light glimmered faintly.

Chapter 1055

Time kept flowing, just as it always had.

It had flowed while the conversation between master and servant ended somewhere in a darkness whose distance and exact location were unknown. And it flowed now, as a young man stopped in the middle of a snowfield that had lost its pure white to blood.

Slosh.

Cold. Sticky.

The blood pooled around his ankles held the deaths of dozens of people. It was also the future of someone standing in it, waiting for death to draw near.

“So this is where you were.”

Kh—cough.

At the young man’s sudden words, the Black Night King Sima Gong blinked through a labored cough.

A face almost exactly like his own appeared in his bleary eyes. He had thought he would never see it again in this life.

“How…”

His words trailed off.

His surprise lasted only a moment. He studied the son who had returned, then spoke in the same calm voice as always.

“I thought you’d gone far away. Why have you come back here?”

“It was too far for me. As I am now.”

The young man, Sama Pyo, answered, then abruptly turned his head to look somewhere.

Amid the unending roar of battle, powerful fighters swept through the remaining enemies, scattering destructive flashes of light. At their center stood Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

“Perhaps… it wasn’t time yet.”

Sama Pyo had wanted to reach him, but couldn’t. He had wanted to help, but in the end had no choice but to turn back.

He knew why the few hundred *jang*[3729] between him and Jin Taekyung had felt like tens of thousands of *ri*[3730]: he wasn’t strong enough.

Yet part of him stubbornly denied something else—the real reason he had come back.

“So, of all the roads you could have taken, you chose to return here?”

“I only happened to see you.”

[3729] One *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3730] One Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi).

You.

It was a dry way to address his father. Sima Gong merely nodded.

“By chance. Yes, I see.”

“Yes. By chance. All of it.”

Whatever they said, father and son both knew this was no coincidence. It was a choice.

Neither saw any need to say so. In that, too, they resembled each other more than anyone else.

“How is the battle going?”

“Is that really what matters to you? When you might stop breathing at any moment?”

“My death is in the future. The battle is happening now. Nothing matters more than what’s before us.”

His father was at death’s door, yet his answer was as firm as ever. Sama Pyo let out a hollow laugh before he could stop himself.

“It’s practically over. The enemy leaders are all dead or have fled. The rest will be wiped out soon.”

It was the plain truth, no more and no less.

The scales that had once tipped toward Dark Heaven’s victory had long since shattered. The Blood-Sword Demon Lord and the mages were dead, and the Grand Sorceress had vanished like a phantom.

Even the powerful Black Ghosts were gone. With the mysterious reinforcements led by the Kongtong Sect now on the battlefield, the allied forces were fighting like men possessed.

Before long, the battle that had stained this vast snowfield red would be over.

No. It was already over.

All that remained was slaughter carried on in the name of battle.

Only after hearing all this did Sima Gong, whose fading consciousness had kept him from knowing it, give a small nod.

“A great victory.”

“A great victory. Ours.”

“Ours. Yes, I suppose you can think of it that way now. The Kongtong Sect may see things differently, of course.”

“The Kongtong Sect…?”

“Don’t pretend you don’t know. You’ve guessed already, haven’t you? The crushing defeat at Dunhuang was no accident.”

Despite the unforgivable crime of betrayal, Sima Gong confessed with pride and composure to the son who resembled him more than anyone else.

“Yes. It’s just as you suspect. I goaded the Gansu sects that opposed me into banding together with the Kongtong Sect to defend Dunhuang, then passed information to the Blood-Sword Demon Lord. I knew what was happening beyond the desert, but I didn’t tell them. If it weren’t for those mounted bandits who came from Ningxia, things wouldn’t have gone the way they did.”

“…!”

“Are you surprised? Angry? Whatever you think of this old man, I have no regrets. I made a choice for gain and survival. Nothing more.”

Sima Gong looked his son straight in the eye.

Gain and survival.

Yes. That was all. It always had been.

He had lived his entire life as a member of the unorthodox faction. To build up a force weaker than the Demonic Path or the orthodox faction—even weaker than the dark-path figures—he had always had to take dangerous gambles.

Just as, after careful calculation amid the great upheaval of the Great Faction War, he had chosen the orthodox faction and claimed the rights of the victors.

His son stood looking down at him in silence. Then he spoke.

“Why did you do it?”

“I’ve told you everything.”

“I’m not asking why you betrayed them. I know what kind of man you are.”

“Then what are you asking…?”

“Why did you make *that* choice? You, who pursued survival and gain so ruthlessly. Why?”

At the look in his son’s eyes, Sima Gong finally understood what he was asking. What answer he wanted.

A brief silence stretched between them, long as an eternity. When Sima Gong spoke, his voice was low and cold.

“You still have a long way to go.”

“What… What does that mean?”

“What’s done is done. The reason doesn’t matter. As my heir, you should be asking what comes next. That’s what it takes to be a Sect Leader.”

“…!”

“Everything will soon be yours. The household and the sect, vast lands and untold wealth… and, most importantly, the grudges you’ll have to settle. Yet you’re curious about the past?”

Sima Gong let out a mocking laugh at his heir.

“I judged you wrongly. You’ll soon gain half of Gansu, only to lose it all. Wolves and vultures will catch the scent of blood and descend from every direction to tear the Black Dragon Demon Gate apart.”

Thousands had died in Dunhuang alone because of his betrayal. The Kongtong Sect had suffered losses comparable to, perhaps even greater than, those it had suffered in the Great Faction War. The same was true of the many sects that formed the roots of Gansu's martial world.

Sima Gong knew what would happen if the truth came out. If Dark Heaven, betrayed for the second time, let even a little information slip, the name of the Black Dragon Demon Gate would disappear from the world.

Even the Zhongnan Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang, might not escape. The crimes of the Roaring Fury Swordsman and the Taeeul Merciless Sword—whether either man was alive or dead—might force the sect to close its gates.

But…

Even when the sky falls, there's a way out. There always is.

Just as Sima Gong murmured to himself, Sama Pyo, who had been watching him with an indescribable expression, finally opened his firmly closed lips.

"There's another way."

"What?"

"A way to save the Black Dragon Demon Gate. A way past the wolves and vultures gathering on every side."

For an instant, a strange glint flashed in Sima Gong's eyes.

"Blood is repaid with blood. That is the law of the martial world. They will never forget what the Black Dragon Demon Gate has done."

"Half right, half wrong," Sama Pyo said quietly. "Blood should be repaid with blood. But not everyone in the Black Dragon Demon Gate needs to bleed."

"…!"

"Am I wrong?"

A heavy silence fell between them.

Screams and shouts still rang out, yet for a moment it seemed every sound around them had vanished.

At last, Sima Gong spoke, his voice low.

"Yes, you're right. The body itself is innocent. It only did what the head told it to. Isn't that so?"

Sama Pyo answered calmly.

"If the head doesn't satisfy them, I'll have to be prepared to cut off the limbs one by one."

"So you mean to cut down this old man and the senior members who followed my orders. Every last one."

"Too many guests will come bearing grudges. Even if each takes only a sip to wet his throat, they'll need a great deal of blood."

“Guests, is it? If you’re receiving guests rather than facing enemies, you’ll have to make the arrangements yourself. You’ll be the host soon.”

“If I cut off the head and arms myself and offer them up, along with reasonable compensation, their grounds for revenge will lose their force.”

“Yes. I suppose they would. Though some may call a son who kills his father with his own hands a monster who has forsaken filial duty…”

“More will call me a hero of turbulent times. A Great Hero of Benevolence and Righteousness, willing to forsake even filial duty for the world and the greater good.”

At that answer, given without hesitation, Sima Gong stared at his son, his face rigid.

His son had just said he would kill his own father.

Then Sima Gong smiled as though his face had never stiffened.

“Truly excellent.”

Forgetting for a moment even the terrible agony that wracked his whole body, the giant who had ruled the unorthodox faction for decades burst into a hearty laugh.

“Yes. This is what I wanted to see from you. This is why I chose you as my heir.”

At that moment, the Black Night King Sima Gong was genuinely happy. He had chosen well. Everything he had built over a lifetime would pass to a worthy successor.

Eight sons and nine daughters. Sama Pyo was his eighth son and his seventeenth and last child.

The youngest and most talented of them all had been his true heir. Now, at last, he had grown into a proper member of the unorthodox faction: a man who could kill even his own father and pursue gain and survival with a cool head in any circumstance.

This is enough.

At the end of his long, hard-fought life, Sima Gong was ready to accept death with a smile of relief.

At the same time, he parted his bloodied lips to speak to Sama Pyo, who was lifting his treasured weapon, the Black Dragon Saber, out of the pool of blood. He addressed the son who had grown from an immature young man into the master of a sect and the new ruler of the unorthodox faction.

“Go ahead and cut me down, Sect Leader.”

At the instant his unfailingly polite voice rang out—

Shwaa!

A brilliant streak of light flashed past his eyes.

Chapter 1056

Shwaa!

The flash that tore through the wind was razor-sharp and perfectly aimed.

The Black Dragon Saber.

It was the first and last treasured blade his father had given him. He had been only a boy in his teens then, though he'd distinguished himself so early that his youth hardly mattered. Now the blade followed its master's hand and cut cleanly through the target before him.

Shhk!

Blood sprayed with a cold slicing sound. The pair of eyes that had watched it all sank deeply.

"What have you done?"

The question held a great deal, but the answer was simple.

"Because this isn't the path I want."

Sama Pyo let go of the hilt, cold beneath his hand.

The keen blade, permitted only to the heir of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, had grazed the bridge of Sima Gong's nose and cut through the pool of blood.

As if mocking the father who had rejoiced to see his son become a true man of the unorthodox faction—and had willingly accepted death.

"This is my choice. The path I, Sama Pyo, have chosen as the man who will succeed you as Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate."

"Why…!"

Sama Pyo calmly met Sima Gong's gaze as his father shouted, his voice thick with blood.

"Because it isn't right."

"What?"

"Because it isn't what comes first—or what's best."

For Sama Pyo, this wasn't a question of what came first.

It was a question of what was right—of what was better.

"I'd forgotten for my whole life. No—I'd grown so used to it that I kept pretending not to know. But not anymore."

His life in Gansu had been one long struggle.

Like the siblings born before him, the youngest of the Sama family had fought desperately to avoid being cast aside.

They were family, bound by blood, and rivals competing for the one position of heir. They were little more than soldiers obeying the man who had given them that blood.

Soldiers who sometimes had to face even death.

“Father, Second Brother…!”

“I’ve already heard from the messenger. We’ll hold the funeral after we’ve wiped them all out. Understand?”

Sima Gong had been a cold conqueror. Unifying the unorthodox faction demanded blood and sacrifice.

It was an open secret that more than five of Sama Pyo’s brothers and sisters had died as the Black Dragon Demon Gate brought every unorthodox faction in the land under its banner and rose to stand alongside the Kongtong Sect.

But no one knew that the Black Dragon Demon Gate’s youngest Young Master, chosen as heir while still in his teens, wasn’t as cold as he seemed.

“Why are you crying so bitterly?”

“Father helped Black Dragon Demon Gate. But he died. Taishan sad.”

“…!”

“Need to find body. Taishan needs to bury father. But, but those people said they don’t know. Taishan sad.”

“…You said your name was Taishan. Come with me.”

Sama Pyo had found the father of the enormous boy weeping before him. He’d found him in the Black Dragon Demon Gate’s uniform, surrounded by crows, and buried him with care.

And for the first time in his life, Sama Pyo had made a friend.

A friend more precious than family—the only person who cared for him more than his own father did.

But he’d never imagined he would make more friends over a decade later.

“Living with them taught me that, in the end, everything depends on the choices I make.”

The Fire Dragon Pavilion.

Despite its grand name, it had fewer than ten members. Among them, Sama Pyo had found a path he’d never known existed.

There were no shackles or labels there.

They always trusted one another and fought together, and that was how they overcame each crisis.

Perhaps that was why Sama Pyo had begun looking back on his life again and again.

Why, at some point, he had begun to feel something unfamiliar toward his merciless father.

“It occurred to me that, when you look at it, you’re rather pitiable yourself.”

“…!”

“You probably weren’t like this from the start. Ambition took hold of you little by little. Then one day, you stopped caring what it took to get what you wanted.”

Gone was the son who couldn’t bear to meet his father’s cold gaze.

Now Sama Pyo looked at his dying father with calm, sorrowful eyes.

“It wasn’t a coincidence.”

“What… do you mean?”

“I didn’t come back by chance. I came to be with you at the end. Not as the Black Night King’s heir, but as Sima Gong’s son.”

Splash.

“Do you know?”

Sama Pyo sat in the pool of blood and met his father’s eyes. Watching them tremble, he continued slowly.

“There is no son in this world who can kill his father.”

“…!”

“I’ll tell them everything myself. I’ll tell them about the pathetic son who knew of his father’s betrayal and tried not to see it.”

“You…”

“I’m not asking to be forgiven. I’m choosing to bear it.”

There was such peace in his answer, such acceptance, that Sima Gong could say nothing.

He could only struggle to hold back a feeling he’d long forgotten—a feeling he had remembered only here, today.

His vision slowly darkened. His breathing grew short, as if signaling the end.

“You asked why I did it. Why I, who’d spent my whole life chasing survival and practical gain, made such a foolish choice…”

To save the heir who would inherit everything he had?

No. That wasn’t it.

At least in that moment, Sima Gong knew there had been another reason.

He was simply too late to confess it.

“I… This father of yours…”

Facing the son who had returned to be with him at the end, Sima Gong used all the strength he had left to force out the words.

He didn’t even realize they were his final breath.

Slump.

His head suddenly drooped.

To his father, who had died so wretchedly, as if burdened by the deeds of his life, the son whispered, “I heard you. Clearly.”

Sama Pyo's shoulders began to shake. The pool of blood soaking father and son trembled with them.

Highly trained hunting dogs always obey their master's commands.

They fix their eyes on the prey he points out, bare their teeth and growl. The moment he slips their leashes, they race forward and tear into it with all their strength.

Until their prey stops breathing.

Or until their master orders them to stop and return.

Just like now.

Shwaa!

A fierce, piercing whistle and a flash of light came from the side.

But speed was always relative.

The Sword Energy surged along a white blade and fell toward the top of my head with all the speed expected of a Peak Master. To me, though, it wasn't fast.

Shhk!

Space split in an instant.

A fraction of a beat later came the slicing sound. Everything in the silver-white spearhead's path had been cut apart.

The Sword Energy, snuffed out like a candle in the wind.

The blade that had carried that mighty energy.

And finally, the body of the person who had launched this futile attack.

Fwoosh!

A tremendous fountain of blood burst from his cleanly severed body. I didn't blink at the sight.

Neither did the other hunting dogs charging from every direction, even now.

Thud, crunch! Whump!

I drove my spearhead into the chest of the first enemy charging straight at me, then crushed the face of another who came at me from the blind spot with one punch. At the same time, I yanked out the embedded spearhead and swung it.

"Ghk—kgh."

Thump.

Three Peak Masters fell with dying cries in place of last words.

No—not three masters.

Three corpses.

But the frenzy of battle sweeping across the blood-soaked snowfield showed no sign of easing.

Shh-shh-shh-shhk!

The Dark Heaven cultists rushed in to fill the gaps without giving me a moment's pause.

At the sight of their blank faces and eyes devoid of feeling, I felt an exhaustion so deep it weighed down my whole body.

How many is that now?

I had no idea.

I had neither the time nor the reason to count every enemy I'd killed.

I could only fight. Keep knocking them down.

Those soulless wooden puppets.

Those hunting dogs, those moths to the flame blindly carrying out their final order even though the master who held their leashes was gone.

Of course, I knew what this was.

A one-sided massacre. Slaughter.

But I had to do it.

It was the only way to end this blood-soaked battle, and the only way to save as many allies as possible.

So I had no choice but to cling with all my strength to the thread of consciousness that felt ready to snap at any moment.

Come on.

I muttered the words to myself and charged toward the enemy.

Or tried to.

That was when my vision began to fade.

"…!"

A red alarm bell rang in my head.

My mental strength had reached its limit long ago. Now, unable to endure any longer, it was sending me a warning.

But by the time I gritted my teeth and forced my eyes wide, it was already too late.

Shwaa!

My view had tilted. A dozen blades were raining down on my body, which had staggered without my even realizing it.

They looked faint. Slow.

My eyesight was still sharp enough to follow them. The problem was my brain: the part that needed to tell my body to move had frozen like stone.

Damn it.

I cursed inwardly as the world slowed around me.

These men were no Blood-Sword Demon Lord or Grand Sorceress. They couldn't even compare to the Black Ghosts.

They fell far short.

Under normal circumstances, I would've scoffed at the difference between us.

Even so, I had a gut feeling I wouldn't be able to dodge all their attacks.

And while my body refused to move, one ridiculous thought crossed my mind.

If I level up, would it heal me even if my limbs got cut off?

Fortunately, I didn't have to worry about that unpleasant first experience—the sort only someone like Cheongpung might enjoy.

The next moment, an enormous rush of air sounded from somewhere and swept my worries away.

Whoooosh!

It happened in the blink of an eye.

A huge shadow rose over the shoulders of the enemies charging toward me. With it came a two-section staff, big and beautiful just as its name suggested, cleaving through the air like lightning.

Craaaack!

If anyone ever asked whether I'd seen five heads knocked flying with a single swing of a bat, I could nod without hesitation.

I could even name the top prospect who'd tear through the modern Major Leagues, now a playground for Awakened Ones.

Of course, that lunatic hulk would introduce himself before anyone else got the chance.

Just like now.

"Taishan! Came! Saw! Hit!"

"Well done! Now, Body Slam!"

Starting with Namho, perched on the shoulder of Taishan—who had just delivered a line to make Julius Caesar weep—familiar faces burst onto the scene like streaks of light.

"Young Master! No, Benefactor! No, Pavilion Master!"

Shhk!

Ju Hwaran split an enemy's skull while blurting out a three-step change of address that even Transformers would've had trouble keeping up with.

"Fools! You dare try to harm the Captain? Your courage is admirable, but first you'll have to get past me—the Captain's right arm and heart! I, Hyuk Mu—whoa, shit!"

Clang!

Hyuk Mujin had charged in with a grand entrance, only to scramble backward when his opponent's counterattack proved stronger than he'd expected.

"Uh, does that guy know how to fight with his mouth shut?"

"You should try shutting yours first."

Thrust!

Song Ilseom saved Hyuk Mujin and cut down the remaining enemies in a flash. And… wait, who was that black, shaggy old guy?

“The Seven Masters of the Black Horse?”

The name slipped out before I knew it. The middle-aged man, a former mounted bandit, twisted his already fearsome face.

“Not Black Horse—White Horse! I’m Ma Junggeol, eldest of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang! Who do you think I went through all this shit for? And you forgot me…!”

“Lower your voice. While I’m asking nicely.”

At Ju Hwaran’s chilling warning, Ma Junggeol clamped his mouth shut. A laugh escaped me before I knew it.

It was just good to see them.

To know we hadn’t lost anyone.

And…

Because I could see the one last person I’d thought I’d never meet again.

“You made it?”

Sama Pyo, who I hadn’t even seen arrive, shrugged.

“Am I late?”

No.

Not at all.

Chapter 1057

No further surprises came in the great battle that day across the vast snowfield.

Just a few shichen[3731] earlier, the forces of Dark Heaven had flaunted their overwhelming might. Now they were no more than candles before the wind, while the allied forces—led by Supreme Peak masters and wave after wave of reinforcements—were like a tremendous storm.

A storm of steel and killing intent, tearing through everything in its path.

Crraack!

Thud! Shhk!

Fountains of blood erupted on every side.

With thick blood mist draped over them like cloaks, the allies charged, stabbing and cutting down every enemy in their path without the slightest hesitation.

An eye for an eye.

A tooth for a tooth.

And death repaid with death. That was the law of this world—of Murim—and the very essence of war.

“Heaven above and earth below, all demons—”

Thwack!

A guard’s spear pierced a cultist’s arm. An arrow and a sword from somewhere tore through his face and chest.

Before the cultists could finish their eight-character doctrine, they fell, spraying blood. The allied forces trampled over their bodies and tightened the cordon around the vast slaughterhouse.

Quickly. Ferociously.

Against Dark Heaven’s cultists, who had lost their reason, persuasion and taking prisoners were luxuries. The immense sacrifices the allies had suffered here today had made them forget mercy.

That was truest of the band who had joined last, yet were now sweeping through the enemy ranks at the very front.

Shh-shh-shhk!

Blood-soaked robes fluttered.

They plunged straight into the heart of the enemy lines as if they cared nothing for their lives. Their movements were elusive as the wind, and the sword light surging from the old man’s blade at their head was cruelly dazzling.

Boom!

A thunderous blast shook the earth.

[3731] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Flesh mangled beyond recognition and blood flew in every direction.

Where the Force had passed, nothing remained.

Nothing but blood and death.

And the tremendous roar of the allied forces as they crashed into the broken enemy formation and crushed it completely.

“Waaah!”

“Charge! Charge!”

“Don’t leave a single one alive!”

In that moment, the allied forces were a single wave, though each part had a different color.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard charged in orderly ranks, keeping their composure amid the chaos.

The soldiers and martial artists of Gansu followed behind them, squeezing out their last strength.

Then there were the Zhongnan Sect Disciples, far fewer than at the start—and the mysterious mounted fighters who had appeared out of nowhere to join the allies.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The ground shook as if an earthquake had struck.

Deafening shouts echoed without end. A forest of steel filled the land, engulfing the invaders and blooming with countless flowers and branches.

Red flowers made of blood, white branches made of bone.

That was how the long, brutal battle ended.

Another half day passed. Of the fully thirty thousand Dark Heaven cultists, not one still stood on the battlefield of his own will.

Not one.

In modern military terminology, annihilation means the loss of combat effectiveness.

Troops, equipment, supplies, morale, and so on.

Generally, if at least thirty percent of a fighting force has been killed or wounded and the survivors’ will falters, the force is judged incapable of continuing to fight—and considered annihilated.

But here in Murim, what lay before Jin Taekyung at this moment was different.

Annihilation.

The word meant exactly what it said.

No, perhaps even that word wasn’t enough.

Killing. Massacre.

Or…

…Slaughter.

The word he couldn’t bring himself to say lingered on the tip of his tongue.

Taekyung looked around, his gaze heavy.

Red. Everything in sight was stained red.

The once-white snowfield. The faces of corpses submerged in pools of blood, their eyes wide open.

And the bloodshot eyes searching for enemies who might have survived, picking through rivers of blood and mountains of corpses.

Shhk!

A sword came down hard, piercing the chest of an enemy who had been writhing among the countless dead.

A miracle wouldn’t happen twice. Having survived once was a misfortune.

If he’d died sooner, his end would have been much quicker and more peaceful.

Craack.

The blade buried deep inside him slowly twisted.

At the dreadful sound of bone and flesh being crushed—and the killing intent, even more palpable than the sound—the faces of the Fire Dragon Pavilion members beside Taekyung stiffened.

“Captain.”

“Even so, this is…”

Taekyung raised a hand to stop them before they could finish.

He knew what they wanted to say.

This wasn’t murder. It was slaughter, like butchering livestock.

Yet he also understood the feelings of those giving such a cruel end to enemies who no longer had the strength to resist.

“Wait here.”

He tossed the words to the Fire Dragon Pavilion members and slowly started walking.

One step. Then another. Unbearable fatigue washed over him with each step, but a hand reached out from somewhere and steadied him when he staggered.

“I’m pretty sure I told you to wait.”

At Taekyung’s mutter, almost spoken to himself, Sama Pyo shrugged.

“Well, I didn’t hear you.”

“You’ve heard me now. Step back.”

“I can’t do that.”

“That’s an order.”

“An order? So that’s how you’re going to play it?”

"Yeah."

Taekyung's voice was firmer than ever. Sama Pyo's answer was just as firm.

"Fine. Then as of this moment, I'm leaving the Fire Dragon Pavilion."

"…!"

Taekyung's eyes widened. Sama Pyo gave him a faint smile.

"What? Didn't see that coming?"

"You…"

"I've enjoyed our time together, Pavilion Master. But this is where we part ways."

He met Taekyung's gaze calmly and added, "I can't keep bringing trouble to you or anyone else. Whatever happens, I'll have to bear it alone."

He knew why Taekyung, who had been at his limit for a long time, was still clinging to consciousness.

And he knew how great a danger might be waiting at the end of the road he now had to walk alone.

He could remain calm because he had already made up his mind.

"Whatever happens, don't get involved. And if something should happen to me…"

His voice trailed off. His gaze shifted toward Taishan—and Taekyung, who had been watching him, cut in.

"Nope."

"What?"

"I said no, asshole. Look after your own man. Don't dump him on someone who's already got enough on his plate."

Sama Pyo fell silent for a moment. Then he understood what Taekyung meant and let out a short laugh.

"You're right. I have to look after him to the very end. I will."

If I can. If I can survive, like you said.

Swallowing the words he couldn't bring himself to say, Sama Pyo set off alone.

Taekyung watched him go, then suddenly spoke.

"Something just occurred to me… Do you remember the day we left the Jin Family of Taiyuan?"

Of course Sama Pyo did.

It had been recent—not years or months ago, but barely more than a month.

And he could guess why Taekyung had brought it up.

"Of course. Right before we left for the west, Elder Namho and Taishan came looking for me."

That night, Sama Pyo had been reading a secret letter from Gansu.

He had already read it, then read it again. Over and over, even as the two approached his door.

“You’re usually punctual to the second, but that day you dragged your feet. Like you were waiting for someone to come looking for you.”

Sama Pyo stopped walking at Taekyung’s quiet remark.

“I had a lot on my mind that day.”

“Elder Namho’s old, but he’s a fine agent. His nose is pretty sharp for his age, too.”

“True. Though his hearing’s bad, so he talks loudly.”

A giant nearly nine feet tall who made the ground shake just by walking, and an old man who talked a lot and had a booming voice.

They stood out wherever they went, and there was no missing the sound of them.

Sama Pyo had heard them that night too, alone in his quarters with the secret letter.

“You planned it, didn’t you? From the start.”

“No. Not at all.”

A blatant lie.

Sama Pyo had been waiting there.

Waiting for his oldest friend, who would come looking for him before anyone else.

No—for the old Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent who was always at Taishan’s side.

Deep down, he had hoped Namho would notice at least something of the secret Sama Pyo couldn’t say aloud.

That he would take it as a warning.

“Why? Why go that far?”

At Taekyung’s quiet question from behind him, Sama Pyo resumed walking.

“Even so… he’s my father.”

He had wanted to believe in him until the very end, whatever it took.

But when that trust was betrayed, he didn’t want the people beside him put in danger.

So he had deliberately left a clue as a warning. Before he could bring himself to report his father’s suspicious actions, he wanted them to become suspicious on their own.

Even if they suspected Sama Pyo too, he didn’t care, as long as it kept everyone safe.

He was used to being suspected and hated.

That was what it meant to live as the blood relative of Sima Gong, the Black Night King, and the Young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

And yet it was strange.

Even after Namho’s gaze toward him had grown sharper and more searching, Taekyung hadn’t said a word.

Not once, even now.

“Then why didn’t you ask me anything? Not once, all this time?”

The question had been circling in Sama Pyo’s mind for so long. The moment he finally voiced it, a short answer came from behind him without a hint of hesitation.

“Even so, we’re friends.”

The answer sent a sharp tingle through Sama Pyo’s chest.

“…!”

“Shit, I don’t know. You look dark and gloomy on the outside, but… I kept wanting to trust you. Even as everything went more and more to shit, I still wanted to.”

Sama Pyo couldn’t say anything.

He clenched his teeth against the heat rising in his eyes and kept walking, his steps unsteady.

Taekyung’s voice reached him from somewhere far behind.

“Don’t die. That’s an order.”

Sama Pyo didn’t answer that gentler-than-ever command.

He kept walking toward the band still moving through the ruined battlefield, slaughtering the enemies who had survived.

Or, to be exact, toward the old man at their center.

Splash.

At last, he stopped, sending ripples through a pool of blood.

Sama Pyo took a deep breath. The stench and reek of blood were foul enough to make him gag, but his heart was strangely calm and still.

As calm and still as the expression of the old man before him, who gazed at his enemy’s son with eyes too deep to read.

“This junior, Sama Pyo, pays his respects to the Sect Leader of the great Kongtong Sect.”

At that moment—

Shwaaah.

Killing intent, immense enough to be terrifying, surged up from every direction and pressed down on Sama Pyo’s entire body.

Chapter 1058

It happened in an instant.

The Blood-Clad Men, drenched head to toe in blood as they slaughtered their enemies, surrounded Sama Pyo and unleashed a terrifying wave of killing intent.

Shhhhhh.

There were about a hundred of them.

Their qi was so fierce that the lingering heat of the battlefield seemed to freeze. The air shifted all at once, and I could feel it clearly.

Even from thirty-odd yards away, where I'd stopped to watch.

And so could the Fire Dragon Pavilion members farther off, waiting as ordered with no idea what was happening.

"My Lord! It's dangerous!"

The killing intent was so thick it seemed to erase the distance between them.

Taishan sensed Sama Pyo's danger at once. With an urgent shout, he launched himself forward—only to be stopped in his tracks.

By me.

"What do you think you're doing, Pavilion Master!"

He practically growled the words, his fighting spirit blazing.

I'd never seen him like this before.

But I couldn't back down either.

This wasn't some damn twist of fate or stroke of bad luck. Sama Pyo had made his own choice.

"Don't go. Not yet."

"Taishan will not obey such an unreasonable order!"

"I'm not ordering you. I'm asking. Just like Sama Pyo asked me not to interfere."

"…!"

Taishan's huge eyes wavered.

The Fire Dragon Pavilion members caught up, but before any of them could speak, Namho cut in with an unusually subdued voice.

Though perched on Taishan's shoulders, he didn't look especially authoritative.

"I know how you feel, but now isn't the time."

"Namho, but—"

"Oh, look at this angry bull!"

Smack!

Namho landed a sharp slap on Taishan's forehead and gave him a stern scolding.

"Was it not enough to let sentiment blind you? Have you gone deaf too? Did you even hear what the Pavilion Master said?"

He was right.

I'd told Taishan clearly.

Not yet… Don't go yet.

That's right. Not yet.

I murmured it to myself and patted Taishan's shoulder as, after a moment's struggle, he lowered his two-section staff.

Then I turned toward the hundred figures radiating killing intent.

The Blood-Clad Men—or rather, the Kongtong Sect Disciples.

At their center stood an old man, watching Sama Pyo with deep, unreadable eyes.

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon.

The Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang. The greatest martial artist in Gansu.

And…

Another man bent on revenge, betrayed by those he'd trusted as allies and forced to lose countless Disciples.

Whoooosh.

His sleeves swelled with the force of his formidable internal energy.

At that moment, the emotionless, ink-black eyes—so deep their depths were impossible to discern—didn't reflect Sama Pyo.

They reflected the bloodline of his enemy: a man Hyeoncheon would gladly tear to pieces.

Rumble.

The air trembled for yards around them. It was hard to breathe.

In the moment the overwhelming qi began slowly tightening around him from every direction, like the hand of an invisible giant, Sama Pyo froze. Then Perfected Being Hyeoncheon suddenly spoke.

"Lately, I keep remembering the first time I met your esteemed father, my friend. It was in the middle of the Great Faction War."

The old Daoist had devoted his entire life to the Dao,[3732] from infancy to old age. His gentle nature had earned him the respect of many.

He had never joined the ranks of the Ten Kings, but even as Sect Leader of the renowned Kongtong Sect, he had always been humble.

Yet even the largest vessel has its limits.

"At the same time, I regretted it. I wondered if I should have killed him then and there."

[3732] *Dao* means "the Way," the central path or principle in Daoist thought.

Sama Pyo said nothing to the deep sigh in Hyeoncheon's voice.

No—he couldn't answer.

He hadn't told the old Daoist the truth, but Hyeoncheon had already glimpsed part of it.

He had first heard of it from a woman.

"At first, I didn't want to believe it. I tried to convince myself it was a ploy to stir up internal strife among the survivors from Dunhuang—that we were being used as stepping-stones for an even greater scheme."

Hyeoncheon had tried to forget what he'd heard while hiding silently in the undergrowth. But his suspicions had only deepened with each passing day.

His distrust of one man: Sima Gong, the Black Night King.

Everything, including the ominous signs he'd sensed before setting out for Dunhuang, fitted together like the teeth of a gear.

"The more I thought about it, the stranger it seemed. Every piece of information we received from the Black Dragon Demon Gate was wrong. And we were the only ones who bled."

Kongtong Mountain, the Kongtong Sect's home since ancient times, lay at the southeastern edge of Gansu. The Black Dragon Demon Gate's territory, by contrast, covered the Dunhuang region in the northwest.

So the Kongtong Sect and the many sects that followed it had acted on information provided by the Black Dragon Demon Gate—and suffered a crushing defeat.

"Thousands died. In that single day."

At the slight tremor in Hyeoncheon's voice, the hundred Disciples surrounding Sama Pyo clenched their teeth.

How could they forget that horrific battle, which had begun like a bolt of lightning?

No. It had been a one-sided slaughter.

"Defending the city meant nothing. When that enormous army appeared out of nowhere, we couldn't do a thing."

The Three Elders of Tianshan.

The three old fiends from Tianshan, returned after decades away, had led the charge. Behind them came tens of thousands of cultists who knew no fear.

Neither the defenders' unceasing volleys of arrows nor the city walls—built of solid stone coated with yellow earth—could stop them.

That immense human tide, black as night, had brought down the high walls in an instant and swept away everything in its path.

It swallowed the lives of fellow Disciples, friends, and family who had stood beside them for years.

“I would rather have fought there with them and died. Heroically, with my last breath.”

Hyeoncheon wasn’t alone in that wish. A hundred pairs of eyes, reddened and now glistening with tears, showed it.

But they had survived.

They’d had to.

If only to avenge those who had died screaming.

“So we ran away like cowards. We received unexpected help along the way and shook off our pursuers easily. The others weren’t so lucky.”

Luck wasn’t shared equally.

Thousands had died in Dunhuang alone. Those who fled in tears were still prey.

They scattered to survive, and thousands more were killed or wounded as they were hunted down.

Yet even after escaping Dark Heaven’s encirclement, Hyeoncheon and the Kongtong Sect Disciples hadn’t returned to the rear.

More precisely, they couldn’t return right away. Every one of them had been injured, some more seriously than others.

The suspicion the Grand Sorceress had planted deep in their hearts had already taken root. And as Hyeoncheon lay groaning from the severe injuries he’d suffered in battle against Dark Heaven, he suddenly realized whose familiar faces had passed through his mind.

It had happened as he hovered between life and death, vowing revenge.

They weren’t the faces of the mysterious woman behind the silver-white veil, or of the Three Elders of Tianshan and the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, who had captured and killed two Elders and hundreds of Disciples.

They belonged to the allies he’d trusted to guard their backs.

“Strange, isn’t it, my friend?”

His voice was low.

After three days at death’s door, Hyeoncheon had barely recovered from his injuries. He’d thought then:

Why?

Why, at the very moment he’d vowed revenge with the bitterness of chewing bear gall,[3733] had they come to mind?

The Black Night King, Sima Gong. The Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il. The Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom.

And the many leaders of Gansu who were little more than the Black Dragon Demon Gate’s servants.

[3733] Chewing bitter gall recalls an East Asian allusion to keeping a resolve for revenge alive.

Why did fire rise deep in his chest whenever he recalled each face and name the woman had revealed from behind her silver-white veil?

In the end, Hyeoncheon had found an answer.

He had come here with the surviving Disciples to confirm it with his own eyes.

And now, before he could begin his revenge, a young man had come to him of his own accord.

"Boy of the Sama family."

His way of speaking had changed.

His voice was steady, edged with iron, but cold flames burned in the old Daoist's eyes.

"Bring me your father. There's something I must confirm before I draw my sword."

Rumble.

The ground trembled faintly.

Sama Pyo looked down in silence at the ripples spreading across a pool of blood. Then he raised his head, which had remained bowed all this time, and spoke.

"He's already gone. To a distant place from which he can never return."

"…!"

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon's eyes flew open.

So did the eyes of the Kongtong Sect Disciples surrounding Sama Pyo, their suffocating killing intent still bearing down on him.

They understood at once what he meant.

He was dead.

The Black Night King, Sima Gong.

The enemy they should have put to death with their own hands. The traitor whose crimes cried out to heaven.

And Sima Gong wasn't the only traitor to meet that fate.

"Sect Leader!"

A grief-stricken cry rang out from somewhere.

A Kongtong Sect Disciple closed a distance of well over a hundred yards in an instant, moving like an arrow. His face was streaked with grief and fury as he threw himself down before Hyeoncheon.

"They… those men…!"

Before his cry could give way to sobs, Hyeoncheon turned.

In the distance, he saw the Zhongnan Sect's flag rising at an angle.

Or rather, the two pieces of white cloth tied to its pole, fluttering weakly.

"A mourning flag…!"

At the anguished whisper that slipped through someone's clenched teeth, the qi surrounding them surged violently.

The white cloth signaled someone's death. Then there was the reaction of the Disciple who had just returned.

The meaning was clear.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il, and the Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom.

The two Zhongnan Sect traitors they'd meant to punish after Sima Gong were gone too.

Gone somewhere no movement technique could reach: the afterlife.

"Dead? You're telling me they're dead? Just like that?"

Grrk.

Hyeoncheon bit his lip.

The flesh split and blood flew, but that pain was nothing beside the agony in his chest, which felt ready to burst.

"How… how dare they…!"

Hyeoncheon flew into a rage.

Despite his still-healing body, his immense qi pressed down all around him. Even the Kongtong Sect Disciples nearby had to hold their breath.

Only Sama Pyo stood his ground.

"I'll take his place."

He barely forced the words out as he endured the Supreme Peak master's qi with his whole body. Hyeoncheon's gaze darkened.

"What did you say?"

"I said I'll take his place. I'll accept the punishment my sinful father owes for what he's done."

Silence fell. Sama Pyo bowed his head to everyone, Hyeoncheon included, and went on.

"I know how presumptuous that is. I know my insignificant life can't make up for the grievances of those who are gone."

He was right.

A person's heart couldn't simply be filled whenever it was emptied.

Nothing could fill a hole once it had been torn open.

You could keep putting things into it, trying to forget. Or you could look at the hole that remained no matter how much you put in and remember.

What had vanished because of a single mistake. The regret of losing it.

That was why Sama Pyo stood here. Why he wanted to walk a different path from his father.

"An eye for an eye. A tooth for a tooth. Death for death."

In Murim, a blood debt between martial artists could only be repaid with blood.

"Strike me down. I won't hold it against you."

And at that moment—

Shing.

A dazzling flash burst from the sword at Perfected Being Hyeoncheon’s waist.

Chapter 1059

For me and everyone else, it lasted only an instant.

For someone, though, it might have felt unbearably slow and suffocating—a moment in a life flashing before their eyes.

Shing.

The sound of sharp steel slipping from its scabbard was so faint it raised goose bumps. The sword had been drawn with near-perfect skill.

Not a hair's breadth off. Just the right force, at just the right speed.

And…

A clear path, following its master's will as the blade cut diagonally across its target.

Shhk!

The distance was too short to dodge. The gap in their martial prowess was too great.

And Sama Pyo had quietly closed his eyes without even trying to evade, as if accepting his fate.

Nothing unexpected happened. The sword light flashed through that split second, scattering red flowers into the air.

Shwaaa!

Time started moving again.

Beyond Sama Pyo's staggering back, a fountain of blood shot high into the air, searing itself into everyone's vision.

The Kongtong Disciples nearby. The Fire Dragon Pavilion members and me.

And someone else, too, who had been doing everything in their power to hold back the urge to rush over.

"No!"

Taishan had watched everything unfold around Sama Pyo with mounting anxiety. That was as long as his patience could last.

With a thunderous shout that rang out on every side, the nine-foot-tall giant set down the poor old man riding on his shoulders as if tossing him aside. Then he shot forward faster than I'd ever seen him move.

Whoosh!

The wind roared around him, but his path was perfectly straight.

Before anyone could stop him, Taishan hurtled like a cannonball toward Sama Pyo's back as Sama Pyo staggered backward.

He didn't seem to care one bit about the Kongtong Disciples who had surrounded Sama Pyo, as if to box him in.

"You bastard!"

“Stop right there!”

Papat!

Shouts erupted from every direction, and figures blurred into motion.

Dozens of Kongtong Disciples moved with elusive speed to block Taishan’s path. Each raised a weapon and aimed it at him.

Their blades were slick with blood. And as if to show how they had survived the brutal, desperate battle at Dunhuang, every one of those blades gleamed with Sword Energy—proof that its wielder had reached the level of injuring others with Sword Energy.

But the two-section staff in Taishan’s hands bore the same light. Even with dozens of Peak Masters blocking his way, he only charged faster.

“Raaaargh!”

Tiger Giant Child.

True to his epithet, Taishan was usually as innocent as a child. But his inborn strength and martial prowess were those of a beast.

Roaring like an enraged tiger, he swung his two-section staff with all his might. A tremendous gale swept along with it.

Whoooosh!

Even a hardened Murim veteran would have felt a chill run down their spine at that terrifying whistle through the air.

But the Kongtong Disciples didn’t take a single step back.

Instead, they met Taishan’s menacing charge with dazzling sword light.

Shwiiing!

Killing intent filled the space in an instant.

The two-section staff crushing through the wind. The blades cutting through it.

Into that life-or-death moment, I took one forceful step.

Shhk.

One step.

That was enough.

Several yards vanished, and the scene around me changed.

I had already slipped between Taishan and the Kongtong Disciples. Without hesitation, I thrust out both palms.

Bang!

Compressed air exploded. A hot blast from the Flame Divine Palm, held back as much as I could manage, burst from my palms and drove everything apart.

The weapons being swung at one another—and the people holding them.

Clatter!

Weapons flew into the air without reaching their targets. Their wielders stumbled backward, swaying like reeds in the wind.

"…!"

"…!"

Dust rose from the blood-soaked ground. Through it, I looked at the bewildered faces of the men forced back and spoke in a tired, flat voice.

"Do you all have energy to burn? Take it down a notch."

Before anyone could answer, I turned to Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, who had watched the sudden clash in silence.

"Apologies for the late greeting. We met once before in Henan."

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon had briefly met me at the Mount Song Resolution, where the new Murim Alliance was first formed. He gave a slight nod.

"It's been a while, my friend Jin."

A corner of my heart ached.

Our acquaintance had lasted less than fifteen minutes, but it still hurt.

The old Daoist who had once praised my martial arts with a kind voice and laugh, like my own grandfather, was nowhere to be found.

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon's voice was as dry and brittle as grains of desert sand. Traces of grief and anger remained around his mouth.

His sword trembled in his wrinkled hand.

Blood dripped slowly from the tip of the treasured blade he had likely carried all his life. Perhaps he still hadn't managed to put those feelings aside.

"Pavilion Master! What are you doing? Move aside, now!"

Right. That guy was here too.

Taishan's shout pulled me out of the feelings I'd sunk into. He had adjusted his grip on his two-section staff and was stepping forward again, so I stopped him.

In my own rough way.

Thump!

My fist drove straight into his abdomen. The nearly nine-foot giant doubled over like a shrimp and went rigid.

Taishan drew in a startled breath. Staring at me wide-eyed, he forced out a few words.

"P-Pavilion Master…"

"Cool your head."

I brought the edge of my hand down on the back of his neck without hesitation.

Thud.

His skin and bones were so thick that even a Pressure-Point Strike looked unlikely to work. But overwhelming force was another matter.

The sound of him falling was like a bear hitting the ground. Silence followed.

The Fire Dragon Pavilion members who arrived a moment later, and the Kongtong Disciples who had been about to charge Taishan again, stared at me in bewilderment.

Everyone except Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, who watched with a somber gaze.

“I’d heard there was a giant tiger beside the young Black Dragon… He’s as strong as they say. Loyal, too.”

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon looked at Sama Pyo, who still lay motionless.

“You have a better subordinate than he looks. Wouldn’t you agree?”

“He’s as dumb as he is big, but he’s a good guy. And…”

I added bitterly, “The friend you showed mercy to is a much better man than you think, Sect Leader.”

“…!”

“…!”

The air around us gave a sharp, electric shiver.

Those who understood what I meant widened their eyes at once, as if on cue. Perfected Being Hyeoncheon closed his eyes without a word.

As though trying to wipe away the urge to kill still lingering in his heart.

“Do you… regret it?”

I broke the silence and looked at him.

From the moment he had drawn his sword and swung it, I’d known instinctively.

There had been conflict in that perfect draw, but not the slightest trace of killing intent.

That the old Daoist’s sword would never take someone’s life.

That was why I hadn’t stepped in.

His wavering sword tip had cut shallowly into Sama Pyo’s flesh, but I could tell it was because of that last bit of conflict.

“Regret it? Of course I do.”

“Then why?”

“His eyes. I saw those eyes.”

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon suddenly opened his eyes. He looked up at the Kongtong Sect flag fluttering above his head and continued.

“They were like my Disciples’ eyes when I last saw them in Dunhuang. Deep and upright. Unbowed even before death. Those were their eyes.”

Some say a person’s eyes are the windows and mirrors of the heart.

Perhaps that was why the old Daoist, who had come here seeking revenge, could not bring himself to kill his enemy’s son, even when the young man had come to him seeking death.

“I’m nothing but an old Daoist. I spent my life absorbed in the sword rather than the Daoist scriptures, and I couldn’t save my Disciples as they bled and died. But…”

A hot breath passed between his trembling lips.

“Someone I met recently said this to me. If you take a person’s life for no reason except that they share your enemy’s blood, what is that if not the Demonic Path?”

I understood.

Though Perfected Being Hyeoncheon was speaking to me, his words were meant for every Kongtong Disciple.

Splat.

A sword slipped from someone’s hand and fell into a pool of blood.

Only moments ago, the Disciples had radiated suffocating killing intent. Now they stared at one another with vacant eyes.

As if the sight of their fellow Disciples, drenched in blood from head to toe, showed them what they themselves had been doing: hunting down the enemies who had survived and slaughtering them like livestock.

They swallowed their tears.

In silence, they struggled to hold back the emotions stirred by the beloved faces passing before their eyes.

“We will have our revenge. But guilt by association will have no place in it. The Kongtong Sect we build anew from this day forward must be that way.”

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon made his declaration to every surviving Disciple.

The tower they had painstakingly built had fallen. They would build it again on bedrock.

And no innocent blood would stain the bedrock beneath that stronger tower.

Then he looked at his Disciples with tear-filled eyes and said, “Cry your hearts out. These may be your last tears today.”

I quietly closed my eyes and shut out the sound.

Every member of the Fire Dragon Pavilion did the same, as did the others who had belatedly noticed the commotion and come over.

The anguished wails and sobs filled the air. There was no way not to hear them, however hard we tried.

But it didn’t matter.

No one on this battlefield, covered in countless corpses and pools of blood, would hear or remember their crying.

Or perhaps…

Maybe everyone was already crying together.

Tap.

At the familiar touch of a hand on my shoulder, I wiped my damp eyes with my sleeve.

“Old Master.”

“I was worried I might be late, but it seems I worried for nothing.”

I turned. Jeok Cheongang and the Bow Saint stood there. They had disappeared somewhere around the time the shouts of victory began to ring out.

No—strictly speaking, they weren't the only ones there.

"Ugh… sob… sob!"

A man was weeping as though his heart would break.

He also smelled worse than anything I'd encountered in my life. I'd spent years being worked like a dog in Gates where just standing still made me gag, but even I had never smelled anything like him.

The strange man suddenly held out a hand to me.

What the hell?

I blinked, my tears already gone, when the oddball grabbed my hand, yanked me close, and wrapped me in a tight embrace. Then he began to sob miserably.

"Waaah! Ooohhh!"

No, seriously. What was going on?

After my brain stalled for a moment, and whatever tears had been about to come out disappeared completely, I asked, "…Um, who exactly are you?"

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation.

"Madman."

"What?"

"Some vicious-looking mounted bandits call him Great Sir, too."

"…!"

Chapter 1060

Great Sir.

An unidentified Supreme Peak master. No one knew his name or anything about him.

About a dozen years ago, he had subdued the lawless Ningxia Province in a single stroke, then defied everyone's expectations by settling into a life of idleness. My first impression of this extraordinary man was:

He looks like a beggar.

That wasn't just a figure of speech. He really did.

His hair and beard were so long they covered his face and reached his waist. Worse, they were matted together.

His clothes were torn and stained in so many places that "rags" would have been more accurate. And the stench coming off his grime-caked body was innovative—no, revolutionary.

A beggar among beggars.

An utter pauper. The king of beggars.

Even Gung Gibang, the Beggars' Sect's Successor Beggar and a bona fide minor chief among its hundred thousand beggars, would take one look at this man and cry, "You beg like shit!" I could guarantee he'd cut the rope tied around his waist.

And yet…

"So this really is the beggar everyone's heard about—or, I mean, the Great Sir?"

"Hard as it is to believe, it's all true."

The Bow Saint answered in a nasal voice. She was already standing well away, pinching her nose shut.

That was when—

"Greeeaat Siiiir! Why did you take so long to come?!"

With a plaintive wail, Ma Junggeol, eldest of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang, came sprinting from far off and threw his arms around the strange man.

Or, more accurately, he tried to hug him, then recoiled as if burned and doubled over like a shrimp.

"Ugh. Blegh."

"…"

Yeah, I understood.

I'd spent enough time rolling around in Gates to be able to stand there and take it. Even now, the stench was bad enough to make me wonder if it could really be coming from a human body.

Of course, even I was reaching my limit.

"Wait, just—give me a little space. Why are you doing this when we've only just met?"

My initial shock didn't last long.

I desperately breathed through my mouth to block out as much of the smell as possible, then tried to push the man away. But his legs were planted deep in the ground like a thousand-geun[3734] boulder. He didn't budge.

Looking at that, he really does seem to be the Great Sir…

Even though I'd held back, my strength was so far beyond ordinary limits that even a decent Peak master would have struggled to withstand it.

My head understood. My heart didn't.

It was like finding out that Kim, the homeless guy who ruled the second exit at Seoul Station, was actually the chairman of a major corporation.

But seriously, why are you crying so hard?

As I stood there, unsure what to do and darting my eyes around, the strange man—no, the Great Sir—who'd been wailing in my arms finally spoke in a congested voice.

"Ahem. Ahem. Forgive me. It was such a moving moment that I couldn't help crying."

I looked down at the front of my chest, soaked and sticky, and corrected him.

"I don't think tears were the only thing coming out."

"My nose was running, too."

I could understand tears and a runny nose, but why he had to let them both out while clinging to me was beyond me. Still, I nodded, summoning the bare minimum of patience and respect for my elder.

"Uh, sure. So you're feeling better now?"

"Thanks to you, I've calmed down a little. Do you mind if I blow my nose?"

"You really do everything, don't you?"

"Hmm? What was that?"

"Nothing. Go ahead."

"Thank you."

The Great Sir thanked me in a guileless voice, then blew his nose with a sound that seemed to clear out his entire head.

Phaaaang!

Into the hem of my clothes.

"Whew, that feels much better… Why are you making that face?"

"…"

Ah.

[3734] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb); a thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

I was really about to snap.

To sum it up, even with half my sanity gone, I somehow managed not to punch the Great Sir in the head.

Starting a fight in the middle of a battlefield that hadn't been fully secured yet would have been unwise. More than that, Perfected Being Hyeoncheon had quickly grasped what was happening and stepped in.

"Here you are, Great Sir."

Anyone would have found the sight surprising. No, astonishing.

Who was Perfected Being Hyeoncheon?

The Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, one of the Nine Sects and One Gang; a hero of the Great Faction War; and a Supreme Peak master representing Gansu.

If we were talking about the Marine Corps, he'd be a legendary first-class veteran who'd taken part in the Incheon Landing Operation.[3735] He had the seniority to stand in the middle of the world and shout, "Everyone below me and above you, fall in!"

And yet this man, whose standing in Murim and martial prowess both ranked among the highest in the world, was the first to offer a fist-and-palm salute with the utmost respect.

To a strange man who looked worse than even the Beggars' Sect leader.

It was enough to make Jeok Cheongang, watching from nearby, mutter:

"What the hell does he have on him…?"

For that moment, I had more or less the same thought.

Maybe the filthy-looking fellow had a video file titled something like *Kongtong's Perfected One H and His Secret Hand Games*.

But there was a reason anyone could understand why Perfected Being Hyeoncheon would show such respect to a strange man followed by a bunch of former mounted bandits.

"This Great Sir was of tremendous help to us."

The story went like this.

After their defeat at Dunhuang, Perfected Being Hyeoncheon and the Kongtong Sect survivors had no idea where to go.

They had to flee east to avoid Dark Heaven's forces gathering like clouds in the west. But now that they felt betrayed by their allies, heading east would have been like walking straight into a tiger's jaws.

So they chose to go north, toward the grasslands.

[3735] The Incheon Landing Operation was a September 1950 amphibious assault during the Korean War.

“We considered turning south for Qinghai, but we had no idea what Dark Heaven might already have done there. We had no choice but to head for the grasslands, where far fewer people lived.”

Though Qinghai lay at the far edge of the Central Plains, there were still plenty of eyes watching from every direction.

The grasslands, by contrast, were vast and sparsely populated, making them better for evading pursuit. If Dark Heaven had reached both places, anyone would have chosen the latter.

“We kept heading north without rest. Even after passing Anxi and entering the grasslands, we couldn’t let our guard down. We thought we might pause long enough to recover, then see what was happening in Gansu. Or perhaps cross the grasslands and go all the way to Shaanxi.”

But for the Kongtong Disciples, already suffering injuries both serious and minor from the fierce battle at Dunhuang, it was a grueling march.

Even Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, who had to lead them all, had reached his limit from a severe Internal Injury.

“Still, we couldn’t stop. Miserable and unsure what lay ahead, we had no choice but to keep moving. Then, after several days on the road, we saw a light flickering in the distance one night.”

The nights on the grasslands were deep and silent.

For the fugitives crossing that endless expanse, any light in the dark was something to be wary of.

“We crept closer, keeping as quiet as we could. A strange man was roasting camel meat. It was the first food we’d seen in four days, and we were all half out of our minds.”

Hyuk Mujin had drifted closer at some point and was listening intently. He let out a low, “Ah.”

“Was that the beggar—sorry, the Great Sir?”

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon nodded.

“Indeed. He saw us shivering in the cold and invited us to sit with him without hesitation.”

“Now that’s generous. He even offered you food. No wonder you’re grateful, Sect Leader.”

The heartwarming story made the air around us feel a little warmer. Then Perfected Being Hyeoncheon spoke again.

“No, we didn’t get any.”

“What?”

“As soon as he saw us, he wolfed down all the meat and told us we could warm ourselves by the fire for a while before we went our separate ways.”

“…!”

"…!"

What the hell?

Everyone's eyes turned toward the Great Sir, mine included. He bashfully smoothed his wild, tangled hair.

"I only had enough for myself at the time…"

The air turned cold again. Perfected Being Hyeoncheon continued.

"Regardless, the Great Sir helped us greatly. He gave every Disciple of our sect, myself included, a place to hide for a while and treated the wounded."

A master could recognize another master.

At first, Perfected Being Hyeoncheon had been wary of the unidentified Supreme Peak master, but he hadn't had any other real options. Before long, he'd come to feel the man's sincere goodwill.

"While we were there, we also had an unexpected visitor."

"An unexpected visitor?"

"At first, we thought the enemy had found our hideout and come to attack. But that wasn't it. It turned out some men called the Seven Masters of White Bones had come to escort the Great Sir."

"The Seven Masters of Baekma Bang," Ma Junggeol interjected through gritted teeth.

"Oh, I must have mixed that up. The Black-Horse Seven?"

"I said the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang! Honestly, this is driving me insa—"

Bap!

I smacked Ma Junggeol on the back of the head without question or explanation and shut him up. Then I looked around.

Quite a few riders were moving across the battlefield on snorting horses.

They wore relatively light leather armor and carried weapons such as lances and crescent-bladed polearms. Now I could finally be sure who they were.

"Then could those people be…?"

"You're thinking of the right people. They're the horse caravans of Ningxia Province."

Ma Junggeol, grimacing as he rubbed the back of his head, spoke in a tiny voice.

"More precisely, the horse caravans centered around Baekma Bang… Gah!"

He clamped his mouth shut when our eyes met. But this time, instead of hitting him, I patted him on the shoulder.

The Seven Masters of Baekma Bang had promised a few days ago that they would bring the Great Sir back. They'd returned with the horse caravans under their command, and thanks to them, we'd been able to deal a decisive, fatal blow to the enemies who were on the verge of collapse.

So that's how this worked out.

I'd more or less forgotten they existed.

Or perhaps it would be more accurate to say I hadn't expected much from them.

You always had to prepare for the worst in a battle, and the horse caravans, made up of former mounted bandits, weren't exactly people you could trust.

But they had kept the promise they made to me, even if they were a little later than planned. And with the Great Sir's help, Perfected Being Hyeoncheon and the Kongtong Disciples had recovered from their injuries and returned to Gansu alongside thousands of horse-caravan riders.

Still, one question remained.

So who the hell is that guy, really?

I looked at the man they called the Great Sir, my eyes full of questions.

A moment ago, he'd clung to me and sobbed as if we were reuniting with a long-lost family. Now he was yawning widely just because the story had gotten a little long. As expected, he seemed far from sane.

Just as Ma Junggeol and his sworn brothers had told me.

Quietly, secretly, I reached out toward the Great Sir.

With a hand of detection, invisible and granted to me alone.

Skill: Activate Qi Sense.

Whoooooosh.

The blue circle spread outward from me and finally reached the Great Sir.

Chapter 1061

Jin Taekyung had two kinds of Qi Sense.

One was the Qi Sense he had honed as a martial artist, a means of survival.

The other was Qi Sense granted by the System as a separate Skill.

The first worked as naturally as breathing, even in everyday life. The second required him to activate the System with a clear intention and goal.

Back when I was weak, I had no choice but to rely on the Qi Sense Skill.

Though he'd used it far less often since his martial arts had reached a certain level, the Qi Sense Skill remained incredibly useful.

Especially when he wanted a closer look at someone whose identity he didn't know.

Skill: Activate Qi Sense.

The moment Jin Taekyung gave the command in his mind, the blue circle of [Qi Sense], now at nine stars, shot outward.

Shwaaash.

The ability made no sound and had no visible form. Only a faint ripple betrayed it, one that a tiny handful of masters at the highest realms could sense.

And it offered another way to determine the identity of the strange man called Great Sir.

If the Skill succeeds, I'll find out exactly who he is. If it fails, I won't lose anything.

Of course, the Qi Sense Skill wasn't all-powerful.

Masters beyond its limits might have their Levels displayed as question marks. Some could sense the ripple when the Skill activated and immediately deflect it.

During their first meeting, Jeok Cheongang had even controlled his qi to make his Level appear absurdly low.

What mattered to Jin Taekyung now was how this beggar-looking Supreme Peak master would react—and what the Skill he'd already activated would tell him.

Who the hell are you?

Jin Taekyung watched him closely.

The wild-haired oddball scratched vigorously at his greasy head, looking so unconcerned that Jin Taekyung couldn't tell whether he had no idea what was happening or was pretending not to.

Then the blue circle that might lift the veil around the man finally reached him.

At the same time, a familiar alert sounded in Jin Taekyung's ear.

Beep-beep!

The sharp noise announced failure. Jin Taekyung knew what that meant.

He's a master. His Level is higher than mine.

But he wasn't shaken.

He'd learned firsthand, more times than he cared to count, that Level was no absolute measure of strength.

Level could reliably distinguish the strong from the weak up to First Rate, or perhaps Peak. Masters beyond those realms were different.

Even back when he was at the Peak realm, Jin Taekyung had won fight after fight against enemies dozens of Levels higher than himself. A Level difference meant especially little to him.

Yet even he was left speechless by the line that appeared before his eyes.

> **System** Skill Qi Sense was half successful!

"…Huh?"

The question slipped out before he knew it.

That wasn't quite what the failure alert had told him. He blinked at the message.

Success was success, and failure was failure. What the hell was *half successful*?

Wait. Now that I think about it, that failure alert did sound a little strange…

Before he could finish the thought, the oddball whipped his head around as though he'd only just noticed something unusual.

"Huh? I thought a strange wind blew over from your direction just now. Did you feel it too?"

Jin Taekyung didn't answer.

No—he couldn't answer. He was too busy staring at something unlike anything he'd seen since gaining the ability to use the System.

> **System Lv. 119 ???**

Three question marks.

That was all.

He rubbed his eyes with his sleeve and blinked hard several times. The question marks remained where the man's name should have been.

…Has this ever happened before?

He already knew the answer.

No.

Not once. Ever.

He'd seen plenty of Levels displayed as question marks, but never a name.

Everyone had a name, whether it was an alias used to hide their identity or the real one someone had given them at birth.

But Great Sir—the oddball before him—didn't.

The sheer strangeness of it left Jin Taekyung with no choice but to ask.

“What the hell are you?”

Bewilderment and a hint of suspicion came through in his abrupt question. Everyone around them looked at Great Sir at once, as if on cue.

His tone had been rude enough to draw a rebuke. Yet even Perfected Being Hyeoncheon and the Kongtong Disciples, who owed Great Sir so much, forgot to give him one.

They’d spent days and nights with their strange benefactor without learning who he was. They wanted to know at least a little about him.

The Fire King, the Bow Saint, and the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion were no different.

A Supreme Peak master who’d spent more than a decade holed up in some remote corner of Ningxia Province was bound to make people curious.

With all those eyes on him, Great Sir calmly asked, “Hm? Were you asking me?”

“Yeah. You.”

“Oh, that’s a very good question.”

Great Sir scratched at his grime-streaked neck. Yellowed teeth showed between his long locks as he beamed.

“Come to think of it, we haven’t even introduced ourselves. Let me do it properly. I’m…”

The surroundings had gone deathly quiet.

Hundreds of pairs of eyes fixed on his lips as they slowly parted.

“Cough. All this dust has made my throat scratchy. Let me start again. I’m…”

His voice trailed off again after he cleared his throat. Everyone was about to go mad with curiosity.

Who could he be?

A reclusive master whose name of three syllables had yet to become known?

A master of the previous generation, long forgotten by the world?

Or perhaps… a former great fiend of the Demonic Cult who had turned over a new leaf?

As their guesses multiplied, Great Sir continued in a grave voice.

“Uh. So, I’m…”

“You bastard, you’re the biggest piece of shit under heaven!”

Jeok Cheongang, halfway out of his mind after hearing “I’m” for the third time, rolled his eyes and started forward. At that very moment, Great Sir let out a cry as though he’d attained some great enlightenment.

“That’s it! I think that’s it!”

“No matter how far the ways of the martial world have fallen, how can you pull this kind of dogshit—what?”

Jeok Cheongang stopped mid-step. Great Sir clapped his hands and shouted again.

“What you said just now! I think you’ve got it! Madman—that must be my name!”

“…?”

“…?”

A suffocating silence fell.

Every last person stared at Great Sir, then at one another. Their eyes exchanged the words no one said aloud.

What the hell?

Did I hear that wrong?

Madman? That’s someone’s name?

Does any of this make sense?

But no amount of exchanged looks changed the reality before them. Seized by a bewilderment he’d felt only a handful of times in his long life, Jeok Cheongang turned toward the person who’d already made him feel it several times.

His one and only Disciple.

“So… what sort of nonsense did that damned fool just spout?”

But, like his Master, his Disciple was just as incapable of fully understanding or accepting what was happening.

If anything, he was even more bewildered.

> **System Lv. 119 Madman**

“…”

Jin Taekyung stared blankly at the holographic window above Great Sir’s head.

What the hell?

It had changed. It definitely had.

But…

So what the hell does that mean?

Could he even call that a proper change? Or had the System developed an error?

Countless thoughts and regrets streaked through his mind like a meteor shower. Then someone he’d momentarily forgotten spoke up beside him.

“Good grief. I thought he’d gotten a little better, but here he goes again.”

Everyone turned toward the voice. The fearsome-looking, middle-aged former mounted bandit flinched.

“Uh, don’t mind him. He’s always like this.”

“Always?”

At Jin Taekyung's question, Ma Junggeol—once a mounted bandit in Ningxia Province, now the Chief of Baekma Bang and eldest of the Seven Masters of Baekma Bang—gave an uneasy nod.

"Well, yes. Didn't I tell you before?"

Jin Taekyung vaguely remembered Ma Junggeol saying Great Sir wasn't exactly normal.

"No, but still. What is this…?"

"A few months ago, when I went to see Great Sir where he was staying, do you know what his name was?"

"What?"

"Jeomsuni."

"…!"

"His name changes every time I visit. He's been Gaettong—Dog Poop—and Sottong—Cow Poop, too."

Jin Taekyung froze, unable to find a word to say. Great Sir suddenly drew a sharp breath and shouted.

"Gasp! Gaettong! Yes! I think it was Gaettong! I'm sure this time! Probably!"

Ding.

> **System Lv. 119 Gaettong**

At that moment, Jin Taekyung gave up on thinking.

Chapter 1062

No matter how easy a life someone leads, they're bound to meet a certain kind of madman at least once.

As for me, my life had been objectively rough—extremely rough—so that went without saying.

But I could say this with certainty:

Even I had never met anyone as purely insane as the oddball they called Great Sir.

…At this rate, should I start an encyclopedia of madmen?

I muttered to myself as I watched Great Sir's back slowly recede into the distance.

Unable to find his true identity as Gaettong, he'd moved on to Sottong (Cow Poop) and Malttong (Horse Poop), completing a trilogy of poop names. Then he'd tried switching genders and becoming Jeomsuni. Jeok Cheongang had threatened to kill him, and now the horse-caravan riders were dragging him away to keep him apart from everyone else.

"I swear on everything I have…"

Standing shoulder to shoulder with me, Jeok Cheongang watched Great Sir go. His voice was grave.

"That man is one of two things: a highly trained Dark Heaven spy, or completely and utterly insane."

Anyone who knew the circumstances would have nodded without thinking. I answered without hesitation.

"I doubt he's a spy."

"It's true that he led the horse caravans of Ningxia Province to help our side. But we mustn't trust him completely. You know that as well as I do, don't you?"

Of course I did. I'd been stabbed in the back often enough to be sick of it.

First the Head Elder of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, then even the Murong Family, one of the Five Great Families, had joined forces with Dark Heaven. Blindly trusting some unidentified Supreme Peak master who'd crawled out of who-knows-where would be stupid.

But…

"There's no reason we can't trust him if we have enough evidence."

"Evidence?"

At Jeok Cheongang's question, I barely moved my lips.

"System."

The brief Sound Transmission reached his ear, and his eyes widened.

I'd already told Jeok Cheongang what the System was, though the word meant nothing in this world. He lowered his voice.

"So what has that marvelous ability of yours told you?"

“He’s mad. Thoroughly mad.”

“Meaning he isn’t a spy?”

“Yes. I can’t say it with absolute certainty, though.”

“If you had to put a number on it?”

“Ninety-nine point nine percent. That’s the chance the madman—no, Great Sir—isn’t a spy.”

“Great Sir, my ass. He’s a lunatic.”

Jeok Cheongang frowned slightly and smacked his lips.

“You’re suspicious of everything, though it doesn’t suit you. If you’re saying this, you must be all but certain… So you think he truly suffers from madness?”

I hesitated, then nodded.

Even I, who thought I had a pretty good grasp of most of the System, had never encountered anything like this. I couldn’t be a hundred percent sure, but otherwise, there was no explaining why Great Sir’s name kept changing from one moment to the next.

At least he isn’t lying. Fooling the System is practically impossible, no matter what you try.

That left only one answer.

Gaettong, Sottong, Malttong, Jeomsuni—whatever the name, Great Sir firmly believed it was his, and the System reflected that belief.

In the purest sense of the word, he was mad.

“He’s dressed so badly that Myriad-Mile Pursuit, that head beggar, would weep. But he doesn’t look old enough to be suffering from the infirmities of old age… I haven’t the faintest idea where that stray cur came from.”

Jeok Cheongang had casually reduced the Beggars’ Sect Leader to “that head beggar.” He frowned, but even he had little chance of working out Great Sir’s identity on the spot.

Too many people remained hidden across the vast Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes, the Four Seas and Five Lakes.

Eccentrics in remote mountain valleys, far from the rest of the world. Heirs of secret sects who had chosen to be forgotten.

Fugitives and killers living quietly out of sight somewhere.

Jeok Cheongang himself had stayed shut away on Mount Jiuhua until he was nearly sixty, devoting himself entirely to martial arts. Great Sir might well be someone like him.

In fact, quite a few reclusive masters had joined the Murim Alliance since it was newly founded at the Mount Song Resolution.

Unlike Great Sir, of course, they must have been thoroughly vetted. The Murim Alliance wasn't a college club. This was wartime, with betrayal and intrigue everywhere.

But how should I put it?

A sudden conviction came over me, and before I knew it, I'd spoken aloud.

"Let's take him in as an ally."

"What?"

"Like I said, I don't think Great Sir is a Dark Heaven spy. No—I'm sure he isn't."

Jeok Cheongang looked at me in surprise. I sounded more certain than usual.

"Well, that's strange. What makes you trust that suspicious madman so much?"

"That's…"

I let the words trail off.

Honestly, I didn't know.

The System didn't tell me who was friend or foe. But alongside my curiosity about Great Sir, I felt a strangely strong conviction that this unidentified Supreme Peak master was not our enemy.

I couldn't give a reason for it, even to myself.

…Maybe I'm just exhausted.

As soon as I remembered how tired I was, my vision wavered. I looked around.

After half a day of fighting, the snowfield was covered in blood and bodies.

People were clearing the battlefield, the brief joy of victory already forgotten.

Birds had gathered in a black mass overhead, circling in the air.

Dark clouds hid the sky. The ground beneath them was red.

Through my wavering vision, it looked like a future that would repeat forever.

"Did we… really win?"

My voice came out faint. Jeok Cheongang answered.

"Yes. At least for today."

But why?

Why, after defeating more enemies than I could count, saving so many lives, and finally winning a great victory that had kept Gansu Province safe—

Why, when I was still alive and breathing—

It didn't feel like we'd won.

I wasn't happy at all.

Not even when a clear chime rang in my ears.

Ding, ding, ding.

> **System** Quest conditions have been met.
> **Mission:** Eliminate all enemies in the Gansu Province area (**Complete**).

> Quest **Path of Blood** successfully completed.
> You have acquired a massive amount of EXP and Fame.
> A new chain Quest has been created.
> Would you like to check the updated information?
> Y / N

I suddenly lifted my head.

Beyond the translucent holographic window, pitch-black clouds still hid the sky. I took a deep breath, and the air that sank deep into my body reeked of blood.

When would I finally be free of this sight?

How much more would I have to suffer, how many more deaths would I have to watch, before I could escape this horrible cycle?

But as always, I had no choice but to answer.

Accept.

It had been a cruel fucking day.

Crack. Crunch.

Beyond the faintly flickering candlelight, a pair of eyes watched a writhing shadow in silence as the gruesome sounds of tearing flesh filled the room.

At first glance, the eyes seemed so deeply sunk that it was impossible to guess what lay behind them. Even so, they held a trace of contempt and disgust—and that look remained even after the tearing sounds stopped.

The shadow's convulsions gradually subsided. At last, it rose and immediately voiced its displeasure.

"You bitch. What's with that look?"

It was a rough greeting after so long apart, but the woman paid it little mind.

She had always prided herself on being rational. She knew better than to expect a mere beast to show human courtesy.

That didn't mean she had anything kind to say to it.

"Wipe yourself off. And stop stinking up the place."

"What? I stink?"

At the woman's sharp words, the shadow started to reply, then gave a quiet laugh.

"Fine. I'll do as I'm told. You're already in a bad mood, aren't you?"

"…What nonsense are you talking about now?"

"Don't pretend you don't know when it doesn't suit you. Don't. It makes you look pathetic."

Swish.

Cloth slid over smooth muscle and skin.

In the darkness beyond the candlelight, the shadow wiped the blood from its body and spoke.

“Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.”

“…!”

“I heard you nearly failed… So, how was it, you miserable bitch? You mocked me last time, but it wasn’t so easy when you had to face him yourself, was it?”

The Grand Sorceress silently bit her lip.

She had little room to argue. It was the truth.

When her silence dragged on, the shadow laughed aloud and continued.

“You should’ve been much more careful. I don’t care if you die, but you nearly caused a serious setback to the grand plan.”

The Grand Sorceress frowned at the continuing taunts and shot back.

“The same goes for you.”

“Isn’t it embarrassing to compare this with what happened then? I caused a bloodbath in the heart of the Central Plains with just a handful of idiots. Even squinting, you can see these are different matters.”

Step.

The shadow—no, the Blood Lord—chuckled as if to mock her, then stepped into the faint light.

“And I had an important item to secure on top of that.”

He had not shown himself since the Shaolin Bloodshed that shook the whole world. Now he crossed the spacious room with a jaunty stride.

He sat in a grand chair that bore the marks of centuries and gave off an inexplicable air of authority. Propping his chin on one hand, he gazed at the Grand Sorceress.

As if he were the ruler of a kingdom.

“Well, enough about the past. What matters is the present and the future. Don’t you agree?”

This time, the Grand Sorceress gave a quiet laugh.

She shook her head and stared at the Blood Lord sitting in the grand chair.

“Stop talking as if you’re someone important. You’re a stupid beast. No—a monster.”

“A monster, huh? To the people of the Central Plains, aren’t we as bad as each other?”

“No. Serving that person is the only thing we have in common. None of us is like you.”

Despite the contempt in her voice, the Blood Lord merely shrugged.

“True. That’s the first thing you’ve got right.”

"…What?"

The Grand Sorceress was taken aback by the response, which was nothing like what she'd expected. A smile, deep as blood, spread across the Blood Lord's lips.

"Of course none of you is like me. No one—not even you—has ever achieved as much as I have."

He laughed gleefully and stroked the grand chair.

More precisely, he stroked the two characters carved into part of it in a bold, vigorous hand.

Kunlun.

A whirling snowstorm swept past the jagged mountain peaks and crept into the Taiqing Hall, where the two of them faced each other.

Chapter 1063

People say that a rumor without feet can travel a thousand *li*[3736], while information with wings can reach tens of thousands of *li* away.

The information merchants of Murim held that saying up as a proverb, and it was no exaggeration.

Flap!

On the day dark clouds covered the sky and death claimed the land, dozens of messenger eagles took flight at once. It was quite a sight.

They left mountains of corpses and pools of blood behind, soaring high and beating their great wings toward separate destinations.

The red-stained snowfield shrank to a tiny drop of blood. The Great Snow Mountain Range, blanketed in eternal snow, disappeared from view.

The sun and moon traded places several times. Day gave way to night and night to day, until the ocher plateau that seemed to stretch to the ends of the world vanished beyond the horizon.

And at last, when the dozens of messenger eagles had each completed their journeys, the realm of the Central Plains seethed like lava in a crater.

“Waaaaah!”

“Long live the Great Nation! Long live His Majesty the Emperor!”

“What are you all doing? Come out! Hurry!”

The news reached different places at different times, but wherever people heard what had happened in Gansu Province, they rushed into the streets and cheered.

Even those roused from a sound sleep before dawn came out of their houses more bewildered than angry.

“Which goddamn fools are making a racket at this hour, when even the hens are fast asleep… Hey, you lot! What the hell are you doing carrying on in front of someone else’s house?”

On an ordinary day, sharp words like those would probably have led to people grabbing each other by the collars first and asking questions later.

But the crowd was too excited. Cheering loud enough to chase away the predawn darkness, they shouted back again and again.

“A great victory! A great victory!”

“What nonsense is that? I asked what you’re doing—wait. A great victory?”

“Good heavens, look at you. You haven’t heard the news yet, have you?”

“You haven’t heard? The rebels from Xinjiang invaded Gansu without knowing their place, and got wiped out to the last man!”

“What? They went after Gansu?”

[3736] A Chinese *li* is a traditional unit of distance, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

Only then did the newcomers' eyes widen. Highborn or lowborn, their shock was the same.

How could it not be?

Just a year ago, Dark Heaven was a name heard only among those with sharp eyes and ears. Now even a peasant scraping out a living in a remote village knew who they were.

The rebels of Xinjiang. Fiends from beyond the desert.

Even the Demonic Cult, which had unleashed the bloodshed known as the Great Faction War half a century ago, could not match Dark Heaven's infamy today.

The Demonic Cult of old had sought to conquer the Murim of the Central Plains. Dark Heaven sought to claim the world itself.

Defying heaven.

Those two characters said it all. Dark Heaven would overturn heaven, defy the natural order, and destroy the unified dynasty and the peace won after countless ages of turmoil.

That was Dark Heaven. And so the people of the Great Nation were still roaming the streets, cheering at that very moment.

"Good heavens, what wonderful news. But just how great a victory was it to get everyone worked up like this?"

At the question, which came from someone now thoroughly awake, a proud voice rose from the crowd.

"Don't be shocked. From what I hear, tens of thousands of rebels were killed or captured in a single battle."

"Gasp! Tens of thousands!"

The numbers were staggering—far beyond those of a mere cult—and so was the victory they represented. They had barely caught their breath when voices elsewhere in the crowd rose to contradict the claim.

"What nonsense! A martial artist I know told me they wiped out a hundred thousand in half a day."

"A hundred thousand? Wasn't it three hundred thousand?"

"What are you all talking about? I heard they crushed more than a million rebels!"

"Come on. There's a limit to how much nonsense a man can talk. A million?"

"Then let's split the difference and call it half a million. No, three hundred thousand."

"Three hundred thousand is still too many. Where did you hear that?"

"Are you with Dark Heaven? Can't you read the room?"

"Why has this suddenly become about—"

"So, are we going with three hundred thousand or not?"

"…Is that up to me?"

“Ah, three hundred thousand! Just so you know, I’m not budging any further!”

“A-all right. I’ll remember it as three hundred thousand. Just calm down.”

“Now we’re getting somewhere. Repeat after me: Long live the Great Nation!”

“L-long live the Great Nation.”

“Speak up! I can barely hear you!”

“L-long live!”

“Much better. Now, long live the Murim Alliance!”

“…When does this end?”

“We’re not done yet. After that comes long live the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—no, the Marquis of Shangshan. Be ready.”

A few people were less than enthusiastic, but most common folk cheered the Murim Alliance just as freely.

It was a remarkable change in public opinion, even compared with only a few years ago.

The orthodox faction, led by the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, had ruled the Murim of the Central Plains. But a long peace had brought corruption, and power had bred injustice.

Did wearing spotless white make the heart beneath it white too?

Still water eventually went foul. Perfect good and perfect evil existed nowhere.

But things were different now.

“Long live the Marquis of Shangshan!”

“Long live the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon!”

It was hard not to marvel at how much had changed because of one man.

Jin Taekyung.

His path, which had begun about two years ago, was as deep and immense as the footsteps of a giant.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan, once slowly crumbling, had become a power that ruled beyond Shanxi Province and across the northern grasslands. It had even joined the Five Great Families. And that was only a fraction of what he had achieved.

Jin Taekyung was the heir of the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, and the successor to the Fire Gate Clan. He was the young giant who had raised the banner of a new Murim Alliance alongside Murim’s most renowned leaders. With martial prowess scarcely believable for his age, he fought Dark Heaven as a man of righteousness.

There was no martial artist under heaven who did not know his name.

No one doubted or begrudged the meaning and weight of the four characters *Blazing Flame Divine Dragon*.

No. No one dared.

Jin Taekyung had proven himself, and countless people had seen it happen.

Nor was his standing confined within Murim’s iron fence.

“To all the people under heaven, hear this!”

The Son of Heaven.

The Son of Heaven, the great ruler who governed the land on heaven’s behalf, had proclaimed his mandate to the world.

The Emperor revealed every scheme Dark Heaven had carried out. He named his only surviving younger brother Imperial Younger Brother and heir apparent, declared the fiends beyond the desert traitors, and tore down in one stroke the solid wall that had stood between the government and Murim for ages.

His battering ram was none other than Jin Taekyung, the Marquis of Shangshan.

“By the command of the Son of Heaven, I order you: unite and fight! Protect your land from the rebels with supernatural powers who dare defy the natural order!”

And so the name Jin Taekyung resounded beyond Murim, echoing across the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes, the Four Seas and Five Lakes.

To martial artists, he was the young giant who would lead a new era. To countless common folk, he was the guardian of the imperial court, the Great General of the realm who obeyed the Emperor’s solemn command and put down traitors.

A martial artist and, at the same time, a marquis personally appointed by the Emperor.

Nothing like it had ever happened in the Great Nation’s history—or anywhere else’s. Yet it was real, and the young hero fought at every moment to bring this terrible age of chaos to an end.

Now he had won again.

“Waaaaah!”

“The Great Nation and Murim have finally united to drive out the rebels! Isn’t it all thanks to His Majesty’s reign and the Marquis of Shangshan’s efforts?”

“On a day like this, there’s no way I’m not getting drunk. Bring me a jar of wine! No—three jars!”

The story swelled as it passed from mouth to mouth. Even without the embellishments, the victory was beyond dispute.

Taverns filled to capacity, and the revelers spilled into the streets, happily raising their cups with the victory in Gansu as their reason to drink.

They praised the Emperor, thanked Jin Taekyung and the Murim Alliance for risking their lives to protect the people of the realm, and took comfort in knowing that they and their loved ones were safe because of them.

They let themselves hope, however vaguely, that the war might soon end without much harm to anyone.

“Come on, drink! Hurry!”

“Down the hatch! That’s it!”

Laughter rang out everywhere. Amid the great feasts, there was not a trace of fear on anyone's face.

Martial artists and common folk alike laughed aloud and reveled in their victory.

For that one day, at least.

Until a peregrine falcon from the distant western frontier of Qinghai completed its weary journey.

When I was a kid, I used to be really disappointed if I couldn't remember a dream from the night before.

It must've been an exciting story, too.

But somewhere along the way, I learned that forgetting a dream meant I wouldn't have to shudder at the feeling a nightmare left behind.

Of course, it didn't mean I hadn't had the nightmare.

"Here."

I opened my eyes on a swaying saddle to find Hyuk Mujin's face in front of me. He was holding out a piece of cloth.

"…What's this?"

"What do you think? Take it. I can't wipe you down myself."

"Oh."

Only then did I feel my clothes clinging to me from head to toe. What the hell had I dreamed about to break out in this much cold sweat?

I know.

Since becoming a Hunter, my nightmares had usually featured one of two kinds of people.

People who'd died because I couldn't save them.

Or people who'd died by my hand.

Actually, there's been one more recently, for the first time in a while.

I remembered it suddenly.

A strange, unidentifiable dream.

Memories that could never have belonged to me, Jin Taekyung of Korea. Memories of a past lived by Jin Taekyung of the Jin Family of Taiyuan.

I was wondering if the dream I'd just had had been like those when—

Screee!

A bird cried out somewhere above me, breaking my train of thought.

As if telling me to focus on the present instead of a dream that might as well have been an illusion.

Right. Now's not the time.

I gave my head a small shake and drew up the Scorching Yang Qi within me.

Whoosh. Crackle.

Steam billowed out, and my damp clothes dried in an instant. Hyuk Mujin's face flushed from the gentle warmth, and he muttered in a dazed voice:

"…Oh. Right. There's that way too."

"Sure. Unlike you."

"…Are you showing off?"

"Yeah."

"Well, when you admit it like that, there's not much I can say…"

Hyuk Mujin let his words trail off, still not quite satisfied. At that moment—

Screee!

The cry rang out again. I looked up at the sky without thinking.

My eyes widened.

"…!"

A blood-soaked missive was tied to the leg of a falcon gliding overhead, its great wings spread wide.

Chapter 1064

If they'd spotted it even a little later, the messenger eagle would have flown right over everyone's heads.

Even messenger eagles, raised with far more rigorous training and care than messenger pigeons, were only trained to fly between set destinations.

But a handful of people, Jin Taekyung among them, noticed it just in time. The Bow Saint was one of them.

When it came to archery, she was the greatest under heaven—perhaps even the greatest in all history.

Shing. Clack.

It happened in an instant.

Steel joints locked together with a metallic clack, transforming her two strangely curved swords into a bow. The Bow Saint drew the string without hesitation.

"Now!"

At Jin Taekyung's shout, she released the taut bowstring.

Boom!

The air tore apart.

A streak of light shot faster than sound and reached the messenger eagle, a distant speck in the sky, in the blink of an eye.

Jin Taekyung, who had anticipated all of this, shot forward at the same moment.

Whoooosh!

He surged ahead like a gust of wind.

In a single bound, he crossed dozens of *jang*[3737] and caught the falling eagle, an arrow through its wing.

Peep. Peep.

"Spit on it and it'll heal in no time, you idiot."

Despite his gruff words, Jin Taekyung stroked the mournfully crying eagle's beak. Then he hurriedly checked its leg.

This is…

He swallowed a groan. A missive had been rolled into a tight little bundle and fastened around the eagle's leg.

Foreboding struck before he'd even read it.

There was no doubt about the reddish substance smeared across the missive. It was blood, spilled from someone's body.

And in his experience, a premonition like this had never been wrong.

Kunlun fallen.

[3737] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The moment Jin Taekyung read the first line of the missive, scrawled in a rough hand, he bit down on his lip without realizing it.

The Kunlun Mountains.

This immense range at the western edge of Qinghai held an ancient history and countless legends.

Its ridges stretched for thousands of *jang*[3738], reaching plateaus and deserts. Its peaks rose high enough to deserve the name of the highest summits.

But the Kunlun Mountains held particular significance for the martial artists of the realm for another reason—one every bit as important as the Kunlun Sect, birthplace of Daoist martial arts and heir to a long history.

“So the pass we had to hold has been breached.”

Jeok Cheongang spat out the words. The missive, already passed through several hands, was crumpled in his fist.

“If what’s written here is true and they’ve occupied Kunlun, then we’ve effectively lost half of Qinghai.”

At his low words, everyone nodded, their faces grim.

Jeok Cheongang was right. Most of the area around the Kunlun Mountains consisted of basins, and that vast region covered nearly half of Qinghai Province. If the enemy held it, the allies had lost control of it.

“Must bring back old memories. Doesn’t it, you old hag?”

The Bow Saint frowned at Jeok Cheongang’s sudden question.

“That’s not something I want to hear from you. Whether you mean my age or the unpleasant memories of the Great Faction War.”

“So how was it at the start of the Great Faction War? When those Demonic Cult bastards crossed Kunlun.”

“It was an unexpected attack. The Demonic Cult’s last invasion before the Great Faction War had been hundreds of years earlier, and even then they’d been soundly defeated before they could cross the Kunlun Mountains. So of course we never expected it.”

But people always fixated on what they couldn’t have.

The Heavenly Demon, who had built the Demonic Cult into a force stronger than ever some fifty years ago, was no exception.

“How many days did the Kunlun Sect hold out back then?”

“Three. They fought for exactly three days and nights before they could hold out no longer and retreated. Their losses nearly destroyed them.”

[3738] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“Three days against a hundred thousand Demonic Cult bastards. They held out a long time.”

He wasn’t mocking them.

The Kunlun Sect had always accepted only a small number of Disciples because of its difficult location and strict rules. It had the fewest Disciples of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

Yet its Disciples were formidable, and the Kunlun Mountains were more treacherous than even the Great Snow Mountain. Together, those advantages had let the sect repel the Demonic Cult’s invasions time and again.

Even so, the Kunlun Sect had its limits.

During the Great Faction War half a century ago.

And now.

The difference was that this time, unlike in the last Great Faction War, when the Demonic Cult dealt the Kunlun Sect a devastating blow as soon as hostilities began, they had made a wiser choice.

“At least they decided to retreat right away. Isn’t that right?”

At Jeok Cheongang’s sudden question, I nodded. I’d been lost in thought.

“Even I think that was the best choice. Facing them head-on would’ve been insane.”

The Demonic Cult and Dark Heaven were different in kind.

I wasn’t talking about the quality or number of their troops. The darkness within Dark Heaven was far deeper and more boundless than anyone could imagine.

Even I couldn’t begin to guess its true size or depth.

But one thing was certain.

“If they’d decided to fight to the death like they did during the Great Faction War, the Kunlun Sect would already have been erased from the world.”

Maybe the Kunlun Sect had realized the battle was hopeless, too.

That would explain why they’d retreated so quickly despite having been joined by Qinghai’s martial artists and government troops—a combined force of some twenty thousand.

The missive said around a thousand people had been killed or wounded during the retreat, but that didn’t change the fact that retreat had been their best choice.

“Fortunately, they withdrew to Qinghai Lake with most of their forces intact. We haven’t lost all of Qinghai yet.”

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, had spoken up. I immediately shook my head.

“You’re not wrong, but at this rate, it’s only a matter of time. The forces left in Qinghai can’t hold them back.”

“That’s…”

"They have magic—no, dark arts with power that's hard to believe. And the Dark Heaven forces occupying the Kunlun Mountains are too numerous to count."

That wasn't a figure of speech or an exaggeration.

I was only repeating what was written in the missive carried by the messenger eagle I'd just caught.

In the missive sent when the decision to retreat was made, a Kunlun Sect Elder had written:

Enemies too numerous to count were filling the mountains and advancing toward them.

At the sight of that overwhelming, terrifying force, he had found himself thinking of a day decades ago.

"…The Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples."

The groan slipped from someone's lips, and the air grew heavy. It was only natural.

Most of those present had already seen it with their own eyes.

They'd felt it on their skin, in every part of their bodies.

Most of the people here had seen and experienced Dark Heaven wield supernatural powers.

They must have felt despair and defeat as they watched a sight that tore down every assumption they'd ever held.

And now there were a hundred thousand.

Even if fear had gripped the Elder who wrote the missive, an army that brought the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples to mind couldn't be far off in size.

And someone I know is probably among them.

Though we'd met only briefly, one unforgettable face passed before my eyes.

The Grand Mage.

No—the *Grand Sorceress*.

I couldn't be certain, but I felt it in my gut. She had survived, and if she had, she would be in Qinghai by now.

If Qinghai falls, there'll be no containing this.

Not just because it was Qinghai. Gansu, which we'd barely managed to protect, was in much the same position.

The realm was one enormous dam. A small crack, and the gap it opened, could bring the whole thing down.

We need time. Time to find a better way to stop them without taking even greater losses.

A headache came on.

But once again, time wasn't on my side.

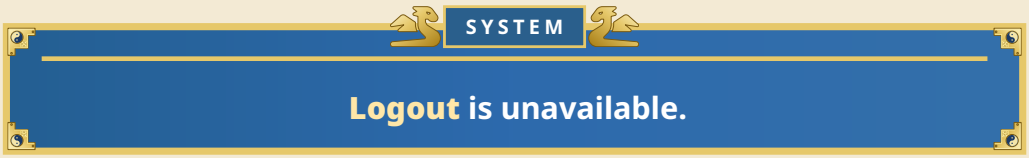
Or rather, not time. The System.

Logout.

I carefully repeated the word in my mind, holding on to a sliver of hope.

The System's answer was calm and cold.

Beep.



"...Damn it."

Everyone's attention snapped to me at the curse that escaped on instinct, but I didn't care.

No. The situation was so fucked I couldn't spare a thought for their stares.

Why?

I'd already spent months in Murim and faced death several times over.

But at some point, the System had shut the door tight and refused to open it.

It blocked my only way back to the modern world, forcing new Quests and a brutal reality on me instead.

Just as it had a few days ago, when we'd finally brought the long, cruel battle at the Great Snow Mountain to an end.

Just as it was doing now.

Crack.

I stared at the holographic window floating before me and swallowed the curse that sprang to my lips.

And, in a stroke of good luck amid all this misfortune, I cursed the System for tossing me a clue like alms in the form of a new Quest title. Then I spoke to a certain lunatic, who was the only one there nodding off like a sick chicken in the middle of this dire situation.

"You said you'd guide us, right?"

"Huh? Yeah?"

Only then did Great Sir blink blearily awake. He wiped the drool from his mouth and spoke in a sleepy voice.

"I think I did say that... So, have you decided where you're going?"

"Yes."

I straightened my back and looked around.

We had all paused here, in the Qilian Mountains. After several days of travel, we'd reached the far end of the range, where a new land awaited us.

Qinghai. Strange and dangerous.

"Let's go."

At my quiet words, everyone's eyes lit up, and they rose to their feet.

Chapter 1065

Losing a battle meant the end.

Especially in a large-scale engagement, with tens of thousands clashing head-on.

The survivors on the losing side had only two possible fates: become prisoners or run to the ends of the earth.

They couldn't choose between them. They couldn't refuse them.

The victors were different.

So, three days ago, just after the bloody battle around the Great Snow Mountain ended in a crushing victory for our side, we were given a new choice.

Would we deal with the aftermath and stay to protect Gansu Province? Or would we move to stop the Dark Heaven forces advancing somewhere else?

We chose the latter.

No—more accurately, everyone respected my wishes.

"I'll be leaving now. There's something I have to do."

The snowfield was covered in flames and smoke that day.

The fire, consuming tens of thousands of corpses, burned as if it would never go out. And my sudden announcement must have felt unbearably cruel to those watching the scene, their tears falling without end.

Yet even though I'd denied them the time to grieve, they didn't blame me.

Not one of them.

Only Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, the Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, stepped forward with a question.

"Where do you intend to go?"

My answer had been decided from the start.

The System had already pointed the way to our next destination with a Quest as clear as a compass.

"Qinghai. Qinghai."

"Which means…"

"Yes. They're coming."

I spoke with a certainty I couldn't explain, but Perfected Being Hyeoncheon didn't ask why. He only nodded, his expression grave.

"The world will be stained with blood once more."

"It will. Without a doubt."

"If we win another great victory against them there, do you think we can bring this accursed war to an end?"

"We'll be one step closer. And the step we take this time will be bigger and deeper than any before it."

“Deep enough to reach the Lord of Heaven?”

“I believe so.”

“Then the Kongtong Sect will stand with you.”

“…!”

“We won’t stop until we reach the end. If only for the sake of the souls who must now be under the care of the Primordial Heavenly Venerable[3739], beyond those clouds.”

If Perfected Being Hyeoncheon had been giving off the same killing intent he’d shown while slaughtering the surviving Dark Heaven followers, I would have refused his offer.

But the old Daoist had lost so much, and his eyes were clear. The same was true of the Kongtong Disciples, who had poured out their anger and grief.

“All right.”

And so Perfected Being Hyeoncheon and about a hundred Kongtong Disciples joined us. But that was only the beginning.

“I, Hyuk Sopyung, a junior martial artist, humbly ask leave to answer for my sect’s sins.”

Hyuk Sopyung, the Zhongnan One Dragon.

Along with him, more than three hundred Zhongnan Sect Disciples who had barely survived the bloody battle set down their weapons and knelt.

The Roaring Fury Swordsman, Song Il, and the Taeeul Merciless Sword, Hwangbo Eom.

The two elders of their sect were dead, and now the Disciples knew what they had done. Shame and grief filled their faces. Blood trickled between their tightly clenched teeth.

If the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, the Zhongnan Sect Leader, hadn’t been unconscious from his severe injuries, he would have knelt beside them and asked to answer for those sins too.

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon watched the Zhongnan Disciples in silence for a long while. Then he spoke.

“A father’s sins do not belong to his children, nor a master’s to his Disciples. Why, then, do the Disciples of Zhongnan ask me to hold them to account?”

“…!”

“Still, if you insist on accepting a penalty, so be it. Follow Daoist Friend Jin here and walk a straight, honorable path. Let that be the Zhongnan Sect’s new way.”

[3739] In Daoism, the Primordial Heavenly Venerable, or Yuanshi Tianzun, is one of the Three Pure Ones, its highest deities.

At the old Daoist's wise and compassionate words, Hyuk Sopyung and the Zhongnan Disciples bowed deeply. Then they gave me a fist-and-palm salute with the utmost respect.

"We wish to walk the righteous path without straying an inch. Great Hero Jin, we ask to join you."

It was the first time I'd come face-to-face with Hyuk Sopyung since the incident at the Yongbong Escort Bureau.

He had once been the Zhongnan Sect's most promising young prodigy, one of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes. The gap between us had grown even wider than before.

Even after spending several days alongside the Zhongnan Sect in Gansu, I'd only ever passed him at a distance. Maybe that was why I'd only just noticed how much more serious his bearing had become, how much deeper his gaze.

"I'd be glad to have you."

For once, I accepted an offer with proper courtesy. Our numbers had swelled to around five hundred with the two sects joining us, and someone watching it all came over.

"Even this won't be enough. Don't you think?"

"Maybe. Still better than padding our numbers with any old riffraff."

"Funny. My ears are itching. Must be my imagination."

"Maybe not."

The new Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate gave a dry laugh at my feigned innocence, then pointed to his new followers, lined up in orderly ranks.

"Five hundred. Time was short, but I chose them carefully from the volunteers. They may not measure up to the Disciples of the Nine Sects and One Gang, but I can vouch for their loyalty and fighting spirit."

"So you're putting them under my command?"

"No. I'd be grateful if you let them come with you."

"What?"

"I, Sama Pyo, Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, and five hundred men ask to join the Fire Dragon Pavilion Master. Please allow us to fight for the realm and make up, however little, for our past wrongs."

"…!"

For a moment, I couldn't speak.

I might not have been able to hold back the emotion welling up inside me if a giant with a little old man dangling from his neck hadn't shouted right then.

"Taishan's going! Taishan's going too! Taishan will go with the Pavilion Master to the end!"

"Goddamn it! Stop bouncing around so much! Please!"

Everyone burst out laughing at once, as if they'd planned it.

Me, Sama Pyo, the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, and the survivors of the Nine Sects and One Gang.

Even Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, whose expression never changed whether he was happy or sad.

"You martial artists are quite an amusing lot."

"Really? Since you brought it up, want to hear something even funnier?"

"Something funnier?"

"Yeah. It's about a certain Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard who kept talking back to a Marquis like he was his equal and is now on the verge of being forcibly discharged. The funny thing is, he has the same surname as you. What a coincidence, huh?"

"…Is that how you're going to play this?"

"Then do your best. So I don't have to."

Jeong Hogun shook his head as though there was no winning with me. Then he stood as straight as an iron tower and saluted.

"Then please give your orders."

"Qinghai. We're going to Qinghai Province. At full speed."

"I, Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, accept the solemn order of the Most Honorable Marquis of Shangshan."

And so, two days ago, the Embroidered Uniform Guard joined us as the final piece of our force. Now nearly two thousand strong, we took a brief rest and headed straight for Qinghai Province.

A few people raised the cautious possibility that Dark Heaven might target Gansu again. The Bow Saint put those concerns to rest with a single remark.

"The North is moving."

Naturally, she didn't mean northern Gansu.

She meant the North of the entire world, divided by the Great Wall—and the two powers that ruled that vast land.

The fierce tiger of Hebei: the Hebei Peng Family.

And the Azure Dragon of Shanxi Province: the Jin Family of Taiyuan, who had now claimed even the skies above the green grasslands.

"Arrows may fly at different speeds, but so long as they hold their course, each will eventually strike its target."

The Bow Saint and the Embroidered Uniform Guard, for example, were arrows shot ahead of the rest.

It was a metaphor worthy of the Bow Saint. No one argued after that.

Not merely because she was the Bow Saint. Everyone knew that with the Azure Dragon and the fierce tiger of the North spreading their wings and baring their claws, Gansu was reasonably safe.

And the brief purge just before we left Gansu was enough to wipe out any possible future threat.

"Anything you want to say before you die? Spare me the excuses. I'll hear your last words."

"I—I never colluded with Dark Heaven. There must have been some misunderstanding!"

"Young Sect Leader—no, Sect Leader! Why are you doing this? You know your late father and I were practically sworn brothers!"

"Yeah, I know. Close enough to betray us together. You were so close that my father wrote it all down in detail… Did you know that?"

"…!"

The meeting meant to decide the future of Gansu's Murim had become a trial of its traitors. The room froze.

Wide eyes. Trembling lips.

Sama Pyo gave a quiet sigh at the sight of them, took a battered old book from inside his robe, and set it on the table.

"So you didn't know. I'd have thought you might at least suspect."

Even I was surprised that the meticulous Black Night King, Sima Gong, had left such conclusive evidence behind. How much more shocked must those men have been, after knowing him for decades?

Sama Pyo went on. There was a trace of bitterness toward his father in his voice, and he looked at the men as though they were insects.

"So. Any last words?"

That did it.

"You—you little brat, with the blood barely dry on your head! You dare kill me, your uncle in all but name?!"

"Heh. Heh heh. So this is how it ends."

A cornered rat had only two choices.

Charge with its adorable little front teeth as its only weapon, or give up and accept its fate.

And waiting for the fools who chose to charge was—

"Story's over, Taishan."

"Yaaawn. Taishan nearly fell asleep listening."

Tiger Giant Child Taishan: designated hitter for the Gansu Black Dragons, with a career batting average of .999.

Wham! Whaaam!

I was there in case anything went wrong, but I never had to step in.

Taishan's two-section staff was gleefully spitting fire—no, blood.

One of the Black Dragon Demon Gate's senior members had shouted that Sama Pyo was a little brat with the blood barely dry on his head, then charged at him. His head was gone before he could spill any blood into it. Several Sect Leaders and Family Heads tried to flee with all their might, but they were surrounded the moment they left the pavilion.

By Black Dragon Demon Gate warriors who had sworn loyalty to their new lord.

And by their own followers and Disciples.

"G-Gangpyeong! How could you do this to me?!"

"How could *you* do what you did, Sect Leader?"

"Guard the way! Hurry! No—this is an order from your Sect Leader! Stop those men right—"

"Shut your filthy mouth."

"What?"

"Because of you, my Master, my Junior Sister, and my Martial Nephew died! That makes you guilty of deceiving your master and betraying your ancestors. Disciples of the Gorang Sword Sect, execute the Sect Leader on the spot, as the sect rules demand!"

"What are the members of the Lanzhou Hyuk Family doing?!"

"Please don't hold it against us, Family Head. You were the one who betrayed us first."

"Y-you dare…!"

Slice! Thud-thud-thud!

Spears and blades came at them from every direction. Around a dozen Sect Leaders and Family Heads died with their eyes wide open, unable even to leave proper last words.

A miserable end for men who had led Gansu's Murim, each the head of a faction with a substantial following.

But the young Sect Leader of the Black Dragon Demon Gate didn't so much as blink as he killed or captured twenty renowned masters in all.

He watched it all with calm, cold eyes. Then, touching his teacup, which had long since gone cold, he spoke out of the blue.

"Should I have them bring fresh tea?"

"No. It tastes awful, and we don't have time. Besides, that scatterbrained man will be joining us soon. Tea will just turn my stomach."

"Great Sir—does he really know the fastest route to Qinghai Province?"

"Ma Junggeol told me he does, anyway. I don't know what he did when he was young, but apparently he knows the terrain inside out."

“I see. Then our business here is done. I’ll go with you, Pavilion Master.”

Sama Pyo nodded and stood.

Only fifteen minutes ago, more than twenty faces had crowded around the table. Now no one remained at it, and all that lay on top were overturned teacups and a battered old book.

“Aren’t you taking it?”

“I don’t need it anymore.”

With that, Sama Pyo left. After a moment’s thought, I picked up the book.

It had served its purpose and been cast aside, but it was still something his dead father had left behind.

I clicked my tongue, turned the first page without thinking, and understood what Sama Pyo had really meant.

“…Huh.”

I let out a dry laugh and set the book down.

No. Not a book.

Just a bundle of yellowed pages without a single character written on them. It had plainly spent years gathering dust somewhere, never once put to use.

“Guess blood really does tell. In a good way.”

Muttering under my breath, I walked on, breathing in the stench of blood flowing from the traitors’ bodies.

Two days passed after that. Then another three went by as we made our way over mountain slopes so rough they made me want to curse.

“Hey, young man. What’s your name?”

“Jin Taekyung. You know that’s the twenty-fourth time I’ve told you, right?”

“Ah, yes. Jang Sam.”

“How the hell does Jin Taekyung become Jang Sam… Forget it. What do you want?”

“Well, it’s nothing terribly important.”

“Tell me anyway. While I’m still speaking politely to you.”

“It’s just that I can’t for the life of me tell where we are.”

“Pardon? What?”

“I asked where we are.”

“Fucking hell.”

I was seized by the urge to kill that lunatic guide for spouting this insanity with a straight face.

A fierce, overpowering urge, strong enough to snap my last thread of self-control.

Step.

I couldn’t hold back any longer. But just as I approached Great Sir to let our fists do the talking—

Ding!

A clear chime rang in my ears, gluing my momentarily severed thread of self-control back together.

Chapter 1066

Ding!

The System notification chimed just as I was striding toward Great Sir with my fist clenched. I stopped.

“You made the right call. There’s nothing to gain by hitting someone who’s already in rough shape… Are you listening to me?”

“Shh.”

Hyuk Mujin had sighed in relief, apparently thinking I’d changed my mind. I signaled for him to be quiet and looked around.

Dense forest lay under the cover of darkness, and insects chirped here and there.

Nothing about the landscape had changed, but all of us had just crossed an invisible boundary. The System was always accurate. It never lied.

Great Sir had somehow fulfilled the task he’d been given. Now he looked as puzzled as the question marks that had floated above his head.

“What’s wrong, Jang Sam?”

“…I’m Jin Taekyung, not Jang Sam.”

To be honest, I’d doubted him right up to the end.

Following someone who couldn’t even remember his own name was hardly a wise decision. He’d kept changing direction along the way, too. Even Sama Pyo, who’d spent his whole life in Gansu Province, had questioned him more than once.

Still.

It worked out.

We’d shaved at least two days off the journey I’d expected. The mountain route had been rough, but the time we’d saved gave us a chance to rest and build up our Stamina.

The question is, how does this guy know a route like this?

The obvious question came back to me. But then Great Sir opened his mouth in a jaw-splitting yawn, and I found myself shaking my head.

What good would it do to keep wondering? The man had been all over the place for ages, and the System had stamped him with its official Madman seal. There was no room left for doubt.

What mattered was that Great Sir was at least on our side. Thanks to him, we had reached Qinghai Province.

More precisely, the area near Qinghai Province’s northwest border.

And this place is…

Right.

Enemy territory, now under Dark Heaven’s control and filled with countless dangers.

Some three thousand people.

That was no small number. In the modern world, a Guild with that many Hunters would easily count as a major one. Even a sect among the Nine Sects and One Gang—apart from the Beggars’ Sect—would have to gather its lay Disciples from outside its main stronghold to reach that number.

But everything was relative.

Dark Heaven’s army invading Qinghai rivaled the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples of old. Against it, three thousand people were no more than fireflies before the sun.

This is urgent, but if we rush straight in with everyone this exhausted, we’ll be the ones getting slaughtered.

So I proposed a day’s rest in the mountains where we’d stopped. No one objected.

Not even Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, whom I’d expected to be the hardest to persuade. If anything, he went out of his way to show me more respect than necessary, which only left me flustered.

“A sound judgment indeed. Very well. What are your orders after we rest?”

“Sorry? My orders?”

“Is something wrong? If you’d rather call them commands, I don’t mind.”

“…I’d rather you curse me out. Why are you doing this to me?”

Was this how a family heir felt when his grandfather’s generation bowed deeply to him during a holiday gathering?

At my thoroughly disconcerted reaction, Perfected Being Hyeoncheon gave a quiet laugh and said something I hadn’t expected.

“Perhaps you should look around you once in a while.”

“What do you mean…?”

“See how many people stand around you. See how they look at you. That will tell you where you stand now.”

“…!”

Only then did I notice how many eyes were fixed on me.

The admiration and goodwill in their gazes were so clear I felt I could reach out and touch them. Gratitude showed in their faint smiles, impossible to hide.

Then Perfected Being Hyeoncheon’s warm voice drifted into my ears.

"Whether you ask, instruct, or command us makes no difference. We all owe you a great debt."

"A debt…"

"In Murim, gratitude and grudges must be repaid. But I have forgiven my grudge. Now I wish to repay the kindness shown to me. I expect they feel the same."

I thought for a moment about how they must feel.

They'd lost comrades they'd shared years of hardship with, family, Senior and Junior Brothers. Before they'd even begun to recover from the fear and sorrow they'd felt on the battlefield, they'd chosen of their own accord to follow me into another deadly place.

They had come to repay a debt, but they were also driven by a desire for revenge that would bring darkness to this land.

And that desire was itself a light against the darkness.

"Ah."

It was a strange feeling. One I couldn't imagine ever getting used to.

I had no idea what to say.

But the old Daoist, whose wisdom matched his long life, didn't demand a reply.

Pat, pat.

He gave my shoulder a couple of silent pats and walked away. Everyone else's attention remained on me.

The Disciples of the Kongtong and Zhongnan Sects.

The martial artists of the Embroidered Uniform Guard and the Black Dragon Demon Gate.

Even Jeok Cheongang and Bow Saint, standing among the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, merely nodded in silence.

As though they'd follow me to the end, even if I were headed straight for hell.

"I… No, I…"

With some three thousand people watching me, I slowly opened my mouth.

And at the very moment the suffocating silence broke, a thought suddenly struck me.

How can it be this quiet?

Only then did I realize that the loud chirping of insects hidden throughout the thick forest had stopped at some point.

The birds perched high in the branches had vanished, too.

"…!"

A chill ran down my spine.

Rumble. Rumble.

A faint tremor finally reached us from far away. With it came the eerie cry of something unknown, carried to my ears on the desolate wind.

Grrrk.

"…Shit."

The curse slipped out on reflex.

I tightened my grip on White Flame's shaft and stared past the darkness at the enemies coming to meet their unexpected visitors.

Then I gave my first command in Qinghai Province.

"Prepare for battle."

Shing! Shing! Shing!

Countless waves of steel rose all at once, their cold gleam lighting up the darkness—and revealing the enemies who had approached behind its veil.

"…A-ah…"

At the low groan that escaped someone's lips, the enemy crawling up the ridge ahead of the others tilted his head.

Plop. Plop.

Pale brain matter dripped from his skull. Nearly half his head was already gone.

Since a time so distant it had left no written record, people had called a vast mountain range at the far western edge of the world:

"The land closest to heaven, its highest peaks touching the clouds…"

The Blood Lord murmured the words to himself, looked around, and nodded.

The mountain range stretched on in endless, overlapping ridges, its many peaks rising here and there. It was majestic and beautiful enough to make anyone gasp.

"Quite a sight. I can see why people of the Central Plains hold this place sacred. And why those worthless Kunlun Sect Daoists fought so desperately to protect it. Don't you agree?"

At the Blood Lord's sudden question, the Grand Sorceress, seated on a large rock and making strange gestures with her hands, answered,

"You seem rather taken with the scenery."

"Well, Tianshan is bleak. You can't deny that."

"Then why not formally ask to join the Kunlun Sect? Who knows? Perhaps you'll become its Sect Leader someday."

The mockery was obvious, but the Blood Lord didn't react as she'd intended. He stared at her with an odd look, then shrugged.

"Not a tempting offer. Got anything better?"

His easy reply made the Grand Sorceress frown.

"What's gotten into you?"

"What do you mean?"

"You weren't like this before."

"Wasn't I?"

The glib answer was nothing like the man she remembered. As she watched him, irritation welled up inside her.

Deranged monster. Acting as if he hasn't a care in the world.

The Blood-Sword Demon Lord had been a bloodthirsty killer, but she found the Blood Lord even harder to stomach.

Stupid, vicious, and utterly shameless.

Those three qualities gave her ample reason to dislike him. But something else bothered her more.

Why does that person keep someone like him so close?

She couldn't understand it.

As far as she had seen, the Blood Lord was neither more skilled in martial arts nor more cunning than the four Demon Lords and the Demon Empress who had died before him.

But there was no denying that, unlike the Blood-Sword Demon Lord, a mere piece on the board, the Blood Lord had his master's trust. And the fact that he stood on equal footing with her only made her more uncomfortable.

And then there was the person sitting just a few *jang*[3740] away, giving off a dreadful stench the entire time.

Jingle. Jangle.

The Grand Sorceress grimaced at the man in black. He sat cross-legged, muttering without pause.

The foul odor drifting over on the wind was bad enough, but the dull, grating jingling of his bells every time he moved was even worse. The more she heard it, the more it grated on her, as though an awl were digging into her ears and unsettling her mind.

"Who is he?"

"My subordinate," the Blood Lord answered readily.

"You had someone like him working for you? There's something oddly familiar about him. And unpleasant."

"That would be because he's a sorcerer."

"What?"

"Oh, don't get the wrong idea. He's a different kind of sorcerer from a certain sharp-tongued bitch. He only joined my ranks recently, actually."

The Grand Sorceress's eyes widened as she caught his meaning.

"Then…"

[3740] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *cheok*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“That’s right. Until a few months ago, he served another Demon Lord. Though, to be precise…”

The Blood Lord’s mouth curved into a smile.

“I suppose he was that Demon Lord’s Disciple, rather than his subordinate.”

At that very moment—

Clatter.

The bell rang again, louder and deeper than before, and the man in black raised his head.

Pale skin. Eyes with a bluish cast.

And a dry voice, without a hint of emotion.

“I found it.”

Not so long ago, Ma Sanbao had held the imperial court in his grasp as the East Depot’s Brush-Holding Eunuch. At his report, the Blood Lord smiled with satisfaction.

“Now that is very welcome news.”

Chapter 1067

Half a shichen[3741].

That was how long Qinghai's first battle had lasted, from beginning to end.

"So this is where you were."

The forest was thick with the smell of blood. I sat on the body of an enemy I didn't recognize, catching my breath, and turned toward the voice.

Squish.

Footsteps strode through blood and mud. A familiar face came into view, clad in armor stained red, its original golden luster gone.

"Shouldn't that be, 'So this is where you were, sir'?"

Jeong Hogun, a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, let out a small sigh.

"So this is where you were, sir. Happy now?"

"Not even close. You dropped the 'sir' again in your very next sentence."

"…Give it a rest. We've both had a hard time."

"I was about to. How bad are our losses?"

"Hardly worth calling them losses. Around thirty casualties, and not a single death."

Jeong Hogun glanced at the heaps of bodies around us and added, "Considering we wiped out more than a thousand enemies, it's a miracle."

Three thousand against one thousand.

We'd had the advantage in numbers from the start, but winning without a single death was an absurdly decisive victory. All the more so when it had taken only half a shichen[3742].

Still, my answer was matter-of-fact.

"It wasn't a miracle. It was only natural."

"I can't argue with that. The difference in strength was overwhelming."

Our troops were all handpicked elites, which had helped. But the Supreme Peak masters had made a far greater difference.

Bow Saint. Jeok Cheongang. Perfected Being Hyeoncheon. Me.

And, last of all, the Great Sir—though he hadn't been much help.

With forces like that, losing would have been harder than winning.

There was only one problem…

"How's everyone doing?"

"What do they look like?"

[3741] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

[3742] A shichen is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

Jeong Hogun's immediate question made me click my tongue.

Honestly, I didn't need to ask. Everywhere I looked, faces were stiff. Despite the overwhelming victory and the few injuries we'd suffered, our allies were pale, with faint fear in their eyes.

As though they'd seen something terrible they were never meant to see.

Which they had.

The unknown enemy still writhing beneath my ass was a monster by any definition.

Grrk. Grrrk.

A faint, guttural cry leaked from its split throat.

Only then did Jeong Hogun notice it. His brow furrowed.

"It's still alive?"

"Maybe. If you can call this alive."

I gazed down at the cursed monster.

Its limbs had been horribly severed, and its body was rotting. It had clearly died days ago, yet it had never crossed the Sanzu River[3743]. It remained in this world, struggling stubbornly, unable even to remember who it had been in life.

But the two characters stitched into its torn, ragged clothes still remembered their owner.

"Kunlun…"

I nodded quietly at Jeong Hogun's low murmur.

That was right.

This monster was a Disciple of the Kunlun Sect.

No—it *had been* one.

"I heard there were casualties during the retreat from Kunlun Mountain. I suppose this was one of them."

"Probably."

"Did you know him?"

I shook my head at Jeong Hogun's cautious question.

"No. Not at all."

I'd met Hak Woo—the Kunlun Cloud Dragon, the Kunlun Sect's greatest young prodigy and a member of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes—at the Star-Array Grand Banquet. But I didn't recognize the face of this Daoist who'd become a monster.

Still, I had a rough idea who might have made him this way.

"Looks familiar, doesn't it?"

"Yes."

[3743]The Sanzu River is a Buddhist river associated with the boundary between life and death.

Jeong Hogun's eyes darkened.

"Cang Gong. It's astonishingly similar to the dark arts he used."

Wei Zhong.

The East Depot's Seal-Holding Eunuch, known as Cang Gong, had harbored two deep secrets.

First, he was the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, one of the Lord of Heaven's loyal servants.

Second, he was a descendant of the Maoshan Sect, which the imperial family had wiped out long ago.

But even after Wei Zhong met his end at my hands, the Maoshan Sect's line hadn't died out.

"Ma Sanbao. It has to be him."

The Disciple who'd inherited everything from Wei Zhong.

Like his Master, he'd worn a mask while operating in secret as an East Depot eunuch. We'd never found his body. That could mean only one thing.

"I wondered where he'd gone. Looks like he survived and joined Dark Heaven after all."

Of course, it might not be Ma Sanbao.

According to Jeok Cheongang, the Corpse Art Wei Zhong had demonstrated had gone far beyond its old limits. That meant it had been improved with the Lord of Heaven's help.

But even if Dark Heaven had trained others in the Corpse Art, none of them would have reached the level of Ma Sanbao, who'd learned directly from Wei Zhong.

Besides…

Qinghai is an important battlefield for them and for us. They'll be throwing more into this fight than ever.

Dark Heaven's army of a hundred thousand had already swallowed half of Qinghai Province.

I had no idea why the Lord of Heaven had intended to lose in Gansu, but this time he was sure to commit everything he had. Even Dark Heaven, with strength far beyond the Demonic Cult of old, wouldn't simply throw away a hundred thousand troops as fodder.

Ma Sanbao is one of the pieces they need to win. They won't leave him out.

A thought flashed through my mind, and I swallowed a groan.

If all hundred thousand enemies had been turned into jiangshi, the disaster would be impossible to stop.

And worse…

The Lord of Heaven might appear on the battlefield himself.

I'd never even faced him properly, yet the thought of those two words made my heart sink.

How could I forget?

The Lord of Heaven had appeared only once, and I remembered every moment of it clearly.

Interesting. Very interesting.

The one who'd smiled at Jeok Cheongang and me that day hadn't been the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

It had been a demon borrowing a human body. The darkness of the abyss itself. An absolute being whom no one seemed capable of opposing.

Until next time.

But after that day, the Lord of Heaven never appeared before me again.

He stayed crouched in the darkness, watching everything.

Even as his loyal servants, including the Western Heaven Demon Lord, met their ends one by one. Even as the plans he'd spent years and considerable effort preparing were dismantled piece by piece.

He never appeared.

But he watched it all, waiting for a moment no one in the world could foresee. A moment only he knew.

And deep down, I sensed that the moment he wanted wasn't far off. I sensed, too, that it was deeply and unmistakably connected to me.

What is he trying to get through me?

Just as I turned that unanswerable question over in my head—

Whoosh! Thwack!

A sharp whistle cut through the air. Snapping out of my thoughts, I heard a shout from not far away.

"Oh, I got it! I got it!"

"Wow! Sir! Amazing! Taishan is truly impressed!"

"Ahem. Did you see that? When I put my mind to it, something like this is easy."

I looked over to find the Great Sir holding a bird and looking rather pleased with himself.

Its head was smashed to a pulp. It looked like it had died from being hit by a stone.

Taishan was staring at the Great Sir—or, more precisely, at the bird—and drooling.

"Tasty—no, impressive! Taishan will start a fire, so let's hurry and roast it!"

A campfire in the middle of enemy territory. It was the kind of bullshit that made everyone else furious, me included. But one lunatic felt differently.

"Young friend, you know how to show proper courtesy. For your trouble, I'll give you some of my meat. Which part would you like?"

"The legs! Definitely the legs!"

“You’ve eaten your share of chicken, I see. Fine, I’ll give you one.”

“Both! All of them!”

“…Don’t push your luck.”

The Great Sir suddenly sobered up. Taishan drooped his head in disappointment, and that was when Namho, perched on Taishan’s shoulder as comfortably as though it were his usual seat, spoke up.

“You’re all making damn fools of yourselves. That thing stinks like hell, wherever it came from. Eat it? Bullshit.”

His words brought a thought to mind.

Wait. Could it be?

The moment Jeong Hogun examined the bird, my suspicion became certainty.

“It’s rotting. The bones are showing.”

“Which means…”

“Looks like the monsters aren’t only on the ground.”

It had been strange enough for a bird to remain there after strangers invaded its territory.

As everyone caught on and turned to look at him, the Great Sir blinked in confusion.

“Is something wrong? It was staring right at me from a branch, so…”

“It was staring at you?”

He nodded.

“I’m certain. Its eyes were bloodred, too. It made me so uneasy that I threw a stone at it.”

“…A Familiar?”

“Hm? What was that?”

“Nothing. Just talking to myself.”

I waved a hand at the Great Sir and stared silently into the air.

Dawn was only now spreading from the east. In its light, I could make out shapes here and there among the branches high overhead.

Monsters hidden in the darkness, brought back to life by its power.

They were already watching us.

My thoughts turned cold as I slowly rose. Then I spoke to the Great Sir, who still looked confused.

“If you see any more birds like that, kill every one of them.”

“Every one?”

“Yes. Every one.”

“That seems a bit much. Aren’t they precious lives, too?”

I considered my answer for a moment.

"They're harmful birds."

"Oh. Then I'll kill them."

"Please."

I patted his shoulder and started to leave, but stopped when I remembered something I'd forgotten.

I reached out and murmured, "Infinite Life Buddha."[3744]

Stab.

The monster stopped moving completely. I left it—the Kunlun Sect Disciple—behind and walked away.

There was no time to spare now.

Eyes were already watching us, and pursuers would soon be on our heels.

[3744] "Infinite Life Buddha" is a Buddhist invocation referring to Amitabha Buddha.

Chapter 1068

If anyone asked me how to shake off enemy pursuers, I'd answer without a moment's hesitation.

There were only two things that mattered:

Speed and stamina.

But knowing what to do and doing it were two different things.

Every one of us knew that, yet reality stood before us like a high, solid wall.

Our force of some three thousand hadn't had a proper rest. The pursuers closing in by the moment were monsters that didn't even feel fatigue.

"Northwest! About two thousand feet[3745] out!"

We'd been coming down the mountains without a break for barely two hours when—

"There! The bastards are here!"

The people who spotted the distant cloud of dust cried out. I immediately turned and sized up the hazy yellow cloud.

Three hundred at least. Maybe five hundred.

The F-rank Hunter who used to scrape by in narrow, pitch-dark Gates was gone.

No—even if some part of that old me still remained, I'd changed in many ways.

I'd learned how to fight multiple enemies and make snap decisions in all kinds of situations.

"Old Master."

We'd reached the point where we understood each other from a glance.

Jeok Cheongang read the meaning in my brief call and immediately poured internal energy into his voice.

"You slowpokes! What are you waiting for? Run like your feet are on fire!"

That wasn't just a scolding from a cranky old man.

Jeok Cheongang's mighty azure dragon's roar shattered the fear lodged in our allies' hearts and hurried their hesitant steps, if only for a moment.

And the great martial artist who'd come to be known as the Bow Saint after countless battles knew her abilities and her role precisely.

"Go. I'll send it at the right time."

I nodded, kicked off the ground, and charged toward the dust cloud.

Whoosh!

The wind split.

[3745] The Korean gives the distance as about 200 *jang*. One *jang* is approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft), so 200 *jang* is about 606 m (1,990 ft).

Dust billowed up from the ground beneath my feet, forming another cloud—one larger and denser than the cloud surrounding the several hundred enemies.

I see them.

Beyond the swirling sand and dust, the monsters who were neither dead nor alive came sharply into view.

I angled up the spear clenched in my hands just as a dazzling streak of light reached the enemy a step ahead of me.

Boom!

An arrow of Force exploded.

Shot from the Bow Saint's fingertips, it swallowed dozens of monsters charging at the front and vaporized them in an instant.

I plunged into the gap it left behind, not about to waste that perfect opening.

Whoosh!

The hair on my arms stood on end at the faint, spine-chilling whistle.

Breath, speed, strength.

As if to prove my skill advanced with every passing day, everything came together without a hair's breadth of error. The strike only grazed the enemies—but that was enough.

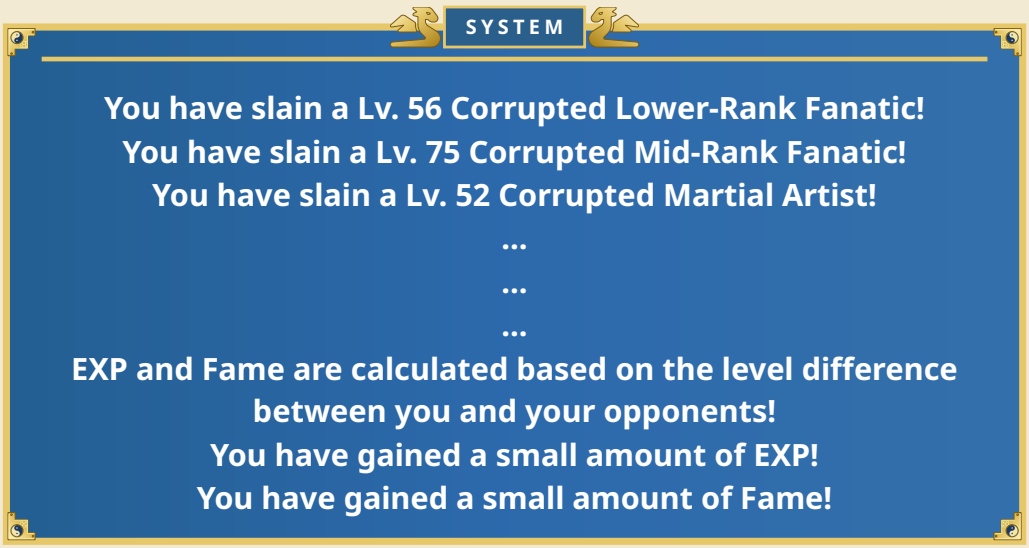
Slice! Splatter!

One cutting sound, but dozens of deaths within it.

A single downward-slanting sweep split rotting bodies and sent blood spraying.

Along with a clear chime, wholly at odds with the horrific sight.

Ding. Ding. Ding-ding-ding!



I swung my spear as if entranced, listening to the System notifications ringing one over another.

Everywhere I looked, there were monsters. Enemies.

Each time my spear traced an arc, a dozen or even dozens of them crumpled like rotten logs, never to move again.

Freed from the chains that had bound them to this world, they returned to the order of things as it was meant to be.

Ding.

At the last chime, I confirmed that nothing else was moving and lifted my head.

Beneath a cloud that half-obscured the sun, a black-winged crow drifted through the air.

Its eyes glowed bloodred.

“Come down. Let’s talk.”

Naturally, I got no answer. I picked up someone’s sword from a pool of foul-smelling blood and added,

“If you don’t like that, come yourself.”

Whoosh!

The sword shot upward, tearing through the air. In an instant, its blade covered the crow’s red eyes.

Stab.

“Hmm.”

The man opened his eyes with a low groan and rubbed the space between them.

The pain that had come with the flash of light at the last moment still lingered, as though an awl were digging into his head.

What a monster. He’s gotten even stronger.

Ma Sanbao couldn’t help but be surprised.

Jin Taekyung’s martial skill, which he’d watched through another being’s senses, had advanced even further than when Ma had seen him at the imperial palace.

Was that even possible? In less than three months?

Ma Sanbao asked himself the question, then shook his head.

It was a stupid question.

The time to wonder whether it was possible had passed long ago.

What mattered was that Jin Taekyung had made it real—and that was precisely what made that young man, not even thirty yet, so exceptional.

Ma Sanbao already knew something else, too.

Unlike Jin Taekyung, his own role was set. He would never be the star of this stage.

For now, his most important task was to watch them closely and report back.

“My Lord.”

Ma Sanbao went to the superior he'd only recently begun serving and reported everything in detail. The Blood Lord listened, then furrowed his brow.

"Wait. They even found out you were watching them?"

"Yes. I'm ashamed to say that's what happened—"

Boom!

A blast of palm force struck before he could finish.

Even an ordinary Peak master would have died on the spot if struck by that blow. Ma Sanbao was swept away by the force, yet despite the tremendous impact, he immediately prostrated himself.

"Huh. Look at how sturdy this body of yours is."

"Please kill me."

"Don't rush me. I was just considering whether to beat you to death right here."

"…My Lord."

"What, are you finally scared? I suppose you have reason to be. Your master ended up dead like that too."

Ma Sanbao bowed even lower.

Unlike his master, the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, Ma hadn't achieved Great Completion in the White Illusion Jiangshi Art. His fear of death was all the greater for it.

"Please show mercy…"

"Shut your mouth. If you want to live even fifteen minutes longer."

The Blood Lord glared down at Ma Sanbao with irritation, but that was the extent of the punishment he could give.

Ma Sanbao was a useful expendable in many ways, and the Blood Lord had never intended to kill one of the few subordinates worth keeping.

He'd threatened Ma so harshly because he wanted to show off his authority and control in front of someone he disliked.

Of course, that someone paid no attention to his display and remained focused on another matter.

"They found out? This soon?"

The Blood Lord answered the Grand Sorceress's question, which sounded almost like she'd asked herself.

"No need to make a fuss. It's sooner than expected, but not all that surprising."

"Looking at the result, sure. That's about as far as your thinking goes."

"What?"

"The Bow Saint, the Fire King, Jin Taekyung. And while he's not on their level, even that old Daoist from the Kongtong Sect. They could've noticed. But that's not what I want to know."

The Grand Sorceress fixed the Blood Lord with a mocking look, then turned to Ma Sanbao.

“Come now. Don’t worry about your foolish superior. Tell me honestly: who was the first to notice your covert surveillance?”

“That was…”

“Once you’ve said something, you can’t take it back. I find it hard to believe the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord would take in a Disciple foolish enough to lie under these circumstances.”

Ma Sanbao hesitated. But when he met the Grand Sorceress’s fathomless gaze, he realized she already knew.

She had guessed what he’d been too afraid to say for fear of an even harsher rebuke from his violent superior.

“It was someone I’d heard of only vaguely, through brief rumors and scraps of information, more than a decade ago.”

At last Ma Sanbao answered cautiously. The Blood Lord let killing intent seep from him, while the Grand Sorceress wore a faint smile, as if she’d expected as much.

“I thought so. The East Depot wouldn’t be what it is otherwise.”

All under heaven lay within the borders of the Great Nation. To watch what lay both inside and beyond those borders, the imperial family had built a watchtower.

That watchtower was the East Depot.

From its commanding view of all under heaven, it had shared what it saw with Dark Heaven through the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord.

“Though the East Depot’s influence has waned in its conflict with the current Emperor, all manner of information still flowed in through the eyes and ears it had planted across the realm.”

“And among them was the man who noticed the surveillance today?”

“Yes. In Ningxia Province, he is called Great Sir.”

“Great Sir. An odd nickname for a martial artist.”

“It isn’t particularly well known, either. He’s a madman, and his past is shrouded in mystery.”

“Even the East Depot couldn’t find out who he was?”

“I can’t say for certain, but at the time, the Emperor was using the Embroidered Uniform Guard to keep the East Depot in check. That clearly limited what we could find out.”

Caught in those overlapping currents of the times, Great Sir had gradually been forgotten.

Until today, when Ma Sanbao dug through his old memories.

As she listened to the story of this mysterious man, the Grand Sorceress suddenly found an answer to a question she’d forgotten.

The Kongtong Sect. I wondered where Perfected Being Hyeoncheon and the Kongtong Disciples who survived Dunhuang had disappeared to along the way…

It was a suspicion close to certainty. At the same time, another question arose, and her gaze darkened.

Who in the world is he?

Chapter 1069

When someone changes in an instant, the people around them can’t help feeling uneasy.

Especially when it happens in the middle of a chase.

“Hh…!”

At Great Sir’s sudden groan, the silence shattered—and the air around us froze.

It hadn’t even been fifteen minutes since we’d shaken off the third group of pursuers.

We’d been moving quickly and quietly, keeping low among the shallow hills and reeds. Now everyone reflexively gripped their weapons. Jeok Cheongang was no exception.

“What is it?”

At his low question, everyone—including me—turned toward Great Sir.

His face had gone rigid without anyone noticing. His pupils, usually a little unfocused, had suddenly dilated, as if reflecting his state of mind. A bead of cold sweat rolled down his forehead.

“I have a bad feeling. A really bad one.”

If we’d been in Gansu, I might’ve wondered what crazy thing he was going to say this time and let it pass.

But however unhinged he was, Great Sir was an undisputed Supreme Peak master. We were in enemy territory, with threats lurking everywhere. And though it might have been a coincidence, he’d been the first to notice the enemy using birds to spy on us. We couldn’t simply brush off what he said.

A person’s innate sixth sense had nothing to do with how advanced their martial arts were.

“A bad feeling?”

Great Sir nodded at Jeok Cheongang’s grave question.

“That’s right.”

“Explain in more detail. And be polite if you don’t want to get beaten to death.”

“Understood.”

Jeok Cheongang chuckled at Great Sir’s answer, then turned to me.

“Would it be all right if this old man taught that lunatic a lesson?”

“Would it?”

“Probably not.”

“Then why ask?”

“I thought I’d check. So it really isn’t all right?”

“You can read his palm, but you can’t lay a hand on him.”

"Damn it. What's become of the code of the martial world?"

Jeok Cheongang sighed up at the sky, then looked at Great Sir with a half-resigned expression.

"Fine. Keep talking. What exactly does it feel like?"

"How should I put it? Like an invisible hand is squeezing my insides."

"And?"

"My stomach keeps churning, and I'm breaking out in a cold sweat."

"Any idea what's causing it?"

"I don't know. It feels familiar somehow, but… Urgh!"

Before he could finish, another groan burst from him.

Great Sir's face went pale, and he moved before anyone could stop him.

Whoosh!

He shot away so fast he left a blurred afterimage. As he vanished among the dense reeds, Jeok Cheongang, the other Supreme Peak masters, and I hurried after him.

Or rather, we were about to.

Then a sound rang out clearly from the reeds.

Prrt, splat-splat-splat!

"…?"

What the fuck?

Just as we all began to dread the answer, Great Sir's voice confirmed it.

"Ahhh, that's a relief…"

"…!"

"…!"

A deathly silence fell. Jeok Cheongang stared at me in disbelief, then finally parted his tightly shut lips.

"Are you sure it's not all right?"

"…"

"I won't kill him. I'll just break one thing. His arm or something, not his leg."

At Jeok Cheongang's earnest plea, Bow Saint muttered through her pinched nose.

"An arm might be all right…"

I'll admit, I was tempted.

But with superhuman self-control, I resisted the urge and shook my head.

Sixth sense, my ass.

If he could just refrain from acting like a complete idiot for once, that'd be a miracle. What had I expected from someone who didn't even know his own name?

Still, he more than pulls his weight.

I swallowed a sigh. Great Shit—no, Great Sir—emerged from the reeds after finishing his remarkably noisy business, looking completely at ease.

"Whew. I feel great."

"…A minute ago, you said you felt terrible."

"Me? I don't believe I did. You must've misunderstood."

"You're really pissing me off."

"Hm? What was that?"

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

"Hm. That's a bad habit. I don't mind, but you should break it soon. If you talk to yourself too often, people might think you've lost your mind."

"…"

I must've lost my grip on reason for a moment.

My vision blurred, and when it cleared, a fierce-looking face was blocking my view.

"Whoa! Calm down, calm down!"

"Let go! Let go! That ugly face of yours is already bad enough. Want me to make it even worse?"

Ma Junggeol—the chief of the mounted bandits who'd somehow ended up following us this far, though he was in the horse-caravan business now—looked at me sadly.

"…That was a bit harsh."

"Ah, sorry. I got carried away."

Some of the sadness left his face at my apology.

"Calm down. You know Great Sir didn't mean any harm."

Of course I knew.

Maybe his innocence was what made it even more infuriating. He'd drawn everyone's attention at a critical moment, and all that fuss had been over a satisfying bowel movement.

Even Shakyamuni[3746] himself would have shouted, "Amitabha,[3747] fuck this! Guanyin,[3748] drop dead!" and cracked Great Sir's skull with a wooden fish.[3749]

But I can't exactly leave him behind.

If pure evil existed, maybe Great Sir was it.

I heaved a sigh and raised a hand where everyone could see it, signaling them to move out.

Every moment mattered, and we'd already wasted nearly fifteen minutes for nothing. We needed to move faster.

At this rate, it could take us several extra days to reach our destination.

[3746] Shakyamuni is the historical Buddha.

[3747] Amitabha is a Buddha invoked in East Asian Buddhism.

[3748] Guanyin is the bodhisattva of compassion in East Asian Buddhism.

[3749] A wooden fish is a wooden percussion instrument used to keep rhythm during Buddhist chanting.

The first attack had come before we'd even made it all the way down from the mountain range. By now, the enemy had caught up with us three times.

Each time, the Supreme Peak masters, including me, had led the charge and wiped out the pursuers. But the important thing was how quickly and relentlessly the enemy caught up to us.

They have eyes to watch us—and monsters that can chase us without resting for a moment.

Monsters that had forgotten death, pain, and fatigue.

That was what made the undead truly terrifying.

Reborn from death, they'd lost their emotions. Though they weren't dead, they were already as good as dead. They'd forgotten sensation, and for the same reason, they couldn't feel fatigue.

We haven't been down from the mountains for long. If they keep slowing us down like this…

The words *surrounded* and *wiped out* rose in my mind. I quietly swallowed them.

Anyone who thought about defeat from the start was bound to lose in the end.

Thousands, or tens of thousands.

Even if a hundred thousand undead came to close their hands around our throats, I had to lead everyone through this dense net and keep moving.

Toward our destination far to the east, where our allies in Qinghai—including the Kunlun Sect—should be waiting.

As if she'd sensed what I was thinking, Ju Hwaran broke away from the others as we moved out and came over.

"If we can make it to Qinghai Lake in the east, they won't be able to pursue us so easily."

Song Ilseom, who—as always—stayed close beside Ju Hwaran like a shadow, spoke up unexpectedly.

"You're not wrong. But only if all of Qinghai's forces have gathered there, and those monsters aren't pursuing us with everything they have."

"…Captain Song."

"No, Young Lady Ju. He's right."

It was a discouraging thing to say, but Song Ilseom's judgment was clear-eyed and accurate.

You could hold on to hope in a corner of your heart, but your head had to question everything.

Plan for the worst and strive for the best.

That was the surest way to survive and win.

"How far is it to Qinghai Lake?"

"Two days if we push ourselves to the limit. I've gone over the map thoroughly, and there's no route that would get us there any faster."

The old map in Ju Hwaran's hands was anything but ordinary.

She'd inherited it from her grandfather, the man known as the Escort King. It marked secret roads hidden throughout the land and described the features of each region in detail.

But this was Qinghai Province.

The northwest in particular was an expanse of open plains and basins, with little but scattered vegetation and reed beds. For us, it was about the worst terrain imaginable.

And for them, it's perfect.

Ju Hwaran had said that even if we pushed ourselves to the limit, it would take two days to reach Qinghai Lake.

If the pursuers kept catching up, it might take three days, four days, or even more than a fortnight.

They're pursuing us harder than I expected. Stealth or speed—we'll have to give up one of them.

That left me with only one choice.

And the first thing I needed to do was obvious.

"Take it off."

I abruptly picked up the pace as I gave the order.

Jeong Hogun, moving hunched over at the rear of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, reflexively asked, "What?"

"Say that again."

"…What did you say?"

"I said take it off. Now."

At the sight of Jeong Hogun's eyes practically shaking, I added an explanation to head off any misunderstanding.

"Don't get any dirty ideas. I'm talking about that damn armor."

I pointed at the armor, smeared with mud to hide its distinctive shine. Jeong Hogun frowned.

"I can't. His Majesty personally bestowed this armor on every member of the Embroidered Uniform Guard."

"So you refuse?"

"That's right. Even an order from the Marquis of Shangshan cannot change the fact that this armor bears the authority and honor of the imperial family."

"And you're willing to die protecting that authority and honor?"

"That's…"

"Fine. Keep wearing it. When you fall behind, we'll just leave you there."

After a brief silence, Jeong Hogun answered.

“On second thought, I believe His Majesty told us to give the Marquis of Shangshan’s orders the highest priority.”

“That’s a pretty ugly excuse.”

“Damn it.”

“I’ll take that as agreement. Don’t waste time—give the order to your men right now…”

I trailed off and stared into the hazy darkness that had settled around us.

Then I sighed and spoke to Jeong Hogun, who had just removed his helmet.

“Don’t take it off yet.”

At that moment—

Rrrrrumble.

A tremor unlike anything the previous pursuers had caused began to churn in the distance.

Chapter 1070

Senses were a source of information.

Through sight, hearing, smell, taste, and touch, people learned what was happening around them.

Just like now.

This is…

The sensation arrived without warning, like an uninvited guest. I held my breath and stared into the darkness, where I could barely make out objects a hundred feet away.

But as martial arts improved, so did the senses. The several jiazi[3750] of internal energy stored within me were more than enough to push mine beyond their limits.

“Don’t take it off yet.”

“…!”

One short sentence was all it took.

Jeong Hogun’s eyes widened, answering for him.

Nearly at the same time—or, no, a hair before me—Bow Saint and Jeok Cheongang noticed the change. They spoke in turn.

“Dust cloud. About a thousand yards out.”

“They’re not like the ones we’ve faced so far. Everyone, prepare yourselves.”

Bow Saint told us what she’d seen and heard. Jeok Cheongang voiced his suspicion.

The same ominous suspicion I’d been having.

Rumble. Rumble.

A vibration traveled through the ground, drawing closer.

But something was different this time.

The rumble was incomparably louder and deeper than anything caused by the pursuers we’d fought on three separate occasions.

What is it?

I strained my senses further and finally caught a new clue.

Boom. Boom.

Amid the constant, faint tremors came the occasional, heavier impact.

No.

A thunderous boom.

The moment I realized, a chill ran down my spine.

[3750] A *jiazi* is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

That sound wasn't something a mere human could make. It belonged to the cursed monsters that should never have existed in this world, yet had become real all the same.

Rooooom!

The boom drew closer and shook the earth. Another layer of darkness and stench spread over the low hill.

And then—

"Grrrraaaah."

Something that could hardly be called human slowly raised its head above the hill, letting out a low, ominous roar.

No. A monster.

The moment the three thousand people saw the cursed monster with their own eyes, they froze.

Even the Embroidered Uniform Guard, whose loyalty was harder than steel.

Even the martial artists of the Black Dragon Demon Gate, who'd weathered every hardship the unorthodox martial world could throw at them.

Even the Disciples of the Zhongnan and Kongtong Sects, who'd spent long years refining their minds and bodies in the Daoist tradition.

In that moment, neither the level of their martial arts nor their experience in the martial world meant anything. Skill, age, experience—none of it could shield them from the shock.

It couldn't have been otherwise. It was only natural.

What the hell… is that?

Everyone had the same thought as the monster appeared atop the hill.

It was huge. Just huge.

Faced with that overwhelming sight, they forgot measurements altogether. Anyone would have, seeing a monster nearly twenty feet tall with a torso as thick as an old tree.

"Grrrraaaah."

A vast hole opened—the monster's mouth—and wind blew from it.

Its cry was too slow to call a roar, which made it all the more chilling. The wind that poured out with it carried more than a horrible stench.

Fear.

It was fear.

The darkest emotion a human could feel—and, for some monsters, a power bestowed at birth.

There was no other word for it. People from another world called that power exactly what it was: Fear.

Hummmmmm.

The people felt the air tremble. Their vision grew hazy, and their legs would no longer lift from the ground.

“P-Primordial Heavenly Venerable…”

The groan that escaped one Daoist’s lips spoke for them all.

Supernatural powers?

The inexplicable?

No. Wrong. Not enough.

What words could possibly describe this moment, this monster, in full? Why had the god they followed allowed such a cursed being upon the earth?

Only days ago, countless followers of Dark Heaven had blackened the vast snowy fields of Great Snow Mountain. Even they hadn’t inspired this much terror.

Nor had the jiangshi who, following the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s bell, had stained the imperial palace’s great banquet hall with blood—the ones the Embroidered Uniform Guard remembered all too well.

At least they’d had human shapes. However far they’d fallen from being human, they’d retained something of their original form.

But—

This can’t be real.

It can’t be. This is impossible.

It’s a dream. Yes. It has to be.

Frozen where they stood, the people stared through distant, clouded eyes at the monster towering over the hill.

If Pangu, the primordial giant said to have opened the world with a single swing of his axe, had existed in some unimaginably distant past, perhaps he’d looked like that.

Of course, unlike Pangu’s majestic myth, passed down through rumor alone, this monster looked as though it had been dragged straight out of someone’s nightmare.

Boom. Rumble!

One step.

But no one who saw the low hill crumble in a single step could call it “just” a step. The monster’s heavy footfall trapped them in endless terror.

It was fear of something they’d never seen or heard of before. Just looking at it felt enough to stop their breath, as if that fear had become an invisible hand squeezing their hearts until they burst.

That was what would have happened—if a dazzling flash hadn't erupted from somewhere at that very moment.

Whoosh!

In an instant, the pitch-black darkness split apart.

Space warped along a deep blue flame, dark yet bright, bright yet dark.

Something that was neither light nor darkness.

Fire.

Hellfire that held both darkness and light, powerful enough to burn and purify everything.

At the very tip of that fire, warping space as it surged forward, stood the enormous monster that had just stepped over the hill.

"Grrrraah!"

Its roar shook the air in every direction. At the same time, an arm as thick as a log swung toward the fire, bursting through the compressed air.

No.

It swung toward the small, unimpressive human flying at it as though he and his flame-wreathed spear were one.

Whoooosh!

A horrifyingly violent rush of air.

But even as the monster's fist, packed with tremendous force, bore down on him, Jin Taekyung's gaze didn't waver. He rushed toward the monster, stepping on invisible stairs in midair.

Neither did his stride, his body hurtling forward—or the silver-white spearhead wreathed in deep-blue flame.

Shhk.

The spearhead suddenly moved with fluid grace, flames rippling along it. Their tremendous heat warped the space around them, making it look as though a fire dragon were moving through the air.

Just like the name of a spear form an old ancestor of the Fire Gate Clan had devised long ago after painstaking thought.

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

The fire dragon's tail glided through the air and met the monster's fist.

Slice!

Everyone on the ground heard the chillingly sharp cut and saw an enormous mass of flesh separate from its owner's body.

The monster saw it too.

"Grr…?"

Puzzled, it looked at its huge fist—or rather, where its fist had been.

Only now did blood begin to bead along the cleanly severed edge.

Splaaash!

Blood erupted in a fountain. The pain arrived a moment late, while the question remained unanswered. Overwhelmed by a feeling it couldn't comprehend, the monster writhed.

It never noticed the spearhead still streaking toward a single point.

Thud.

The monster felt something so hot its vision turned white, yet so cold it shuddered.

The spearhead had driven straight into its throat. It cut off the roar the monster had been about to unleash and poured out a fire it couldn't possibly resist.

Just like the eyes of the man filling its vision.

"This isn't a Troll or an ogre… What the hell are you?"

Jin Taekyung's voice was low.

The monster lacked the intelligence to understand him. He saw as much in its large, bewildered eyes.

"Yeah. I figured. That's all you were allowed, isn't it?"

A monster's Intelligence was proportional to its strength.

Jin Taekyung murmured the words as he studied it with a somber gaze. Unable to make a sound past the spearhead in its throat, the monster stared back at him, its eyes slowly dimming. He clenched his teeth.

"Who brought you into being? How?"

He wasn't asking the monster for an answer.

It was a question for himself—and for the other enemies appearing beyond the giant's shoulder.

Boom! Rumble!

Large and small shadows, cloaked in darkness, surged forward like a wave.

The ground, which had trembled faintly, now shook violently, as though an earthquake had begun. And it wasn't happening in just one direction.

Rumble.

Beneath the tremendous noise of the enemies now a few hundred feet away, he felt fainter vibrations. They came from farther off, layer upon layer, in every direction.

Jin Taekyung muttered without realizing it.

"…A net over heaven and earth."

There was no doubt. They'd been surrounded—and with meticulous care.

He knew better than anyone that low-Intelligence monsters could never have formed a net like this on their own.

Jingle. Jingle.

Faint bells sounded from all around, carried on the wind. Jin Taekyung twisted the spearhead embedded deep in the monster.

Crack. Splaaash!

The monster died without a final cry. Its body crumpled, and foul-smelling blood burst out, soaking his collar.

He didn’t care.

He’d have to be drenched in their blood countless times before the night was over. Perhaps for days to come.

It was the only way to tear through this horrifyingly tight net and make it east.

“You all saw that, right? These fuckers ain’t shit.”

Jin Taekyung spoke to everyone.

East, west, south, north.

There was nowhere to run. All they could do was fight.

“Let’s go.”

At his low command, three thousand weapons leveled toward the enemy.

Chapter 1071

I quickly took stock of our surroundings.

First, I gauged the enemy's numbers from the dust clouds rolling in on every side and the force of the tremors coming through the ground.

At least ten thousand. No fewer than that.

Things weren't looking good.

Even a rough count put them at more than three times our numbers. And the enemies closing in by the second were monsters that neither tired nor died easily.

There might even be another mutant like that one among them.

I turned toward the giant's corpse. Its head was split in half, and it was dead for good.

Whatever that enormous thing had been, it wasn't a Troll or an ogre. The monster encyclopedia recorded every kind of monster to appear since the Great Cataclysm had plunged the modern twenty-first century into chaos, and there was nothing like it in there.

As I'd thought earlier, *mutant* was the only word that fit. The same went for the other monsters that had begun appearing in Murim some time ago.

Right. It's the same pattern as before.

This wasn't the first time mutants had appeared.

Similar things had happened in Hubei and at the Nanman Beast Palace.

And I remembered clearly what had been at the center of those incidents every time: followers of the Lord of Heaven and the *rifts* they had brought about.

If that's the case, could it be…?

An ominous thought flashed through my mind. I shook my head and pushed it aside.

Even if it was true, dealing with the enemies in front of us came first.

"Sama Pyo. Jeong Hogun."

I spoke abruptly, looking the two of them straight in the eye.

"You'll take the left and right flanks."

They bowed without a word and moved at once.

Each commanded a thousand men. They would form our two wings, with help from a certain Supreme Peak master who'd held us up at the worst possible time—and, by a ridiculous coincidence, bought us time to prepare for the enemy.

"Great Sir."

"Hm? Me? Can't I sit this one out? I don't have any particular grudge against them."

"Fuck, Great Sir."

"…Where should I go?"

"Both flanks. Move between them and help whichever one's in trouble."

"Ugh. All right."

That would make our wings sharper and sturdier. Great Sir's mind might wander, but a flank with a Supreme Peak master to support it wouldn't break easily.

"And what would you have me do?"

I answered Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, the Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, at once.

"Please take the rear with the Kongtong Disciples, Sect Leader."

"It's unfortunate that the Zhongnan Sect has taken the vanguard from us, but in this situation, our sect must play the most important role. I understand your intentions, Daoist Friend.[3751]"

With the enemy's encirclement nearly complete, the rear mattered more than the vanguard.

Hyeoncheon understood tactics better than most martial artists. He was a veteran who'd fought his way through the Great Faction War, and he'd grasped my intention immediately.

But even he hadn't seen the whole picture.

"The Zhongnan Sect won't take the vanguard."

"What do you mean?"

Leaving Hyeoncheon looking puzzled, I called to a man who stood gripping his sword, his face tense.

"Hyuk Sopyung. You and the Zhongnan Sect will help the Kongtong Sect take the rear."

Hyuk Sopyung—the Zhongnan One Dragon—stared at me, wide-eyed.

He was leading Zhongnan's surviving Disciples in place of the Wind-and-Cloud Sword Lord, who'd been severely injured at Great Snow Mountain and had been forced to remain in Gansu.

And he wasn't the only one surprised. Everyone nearby had been hanging on my every word, and they all reacted the same way.

"Then who's taking the vanguard…?"

As Hyuk Sopyung trailed off, a rough voice cut through the crowd.

"What are you standing around for? Get your asses to the rear."

The Fire King. Jeok Cheongang.

Beside the giant who'd stamped his mark so violently on the vast martial world stood a woman known not as a king, but as a star.

Click.

[3751] Daoist Friend is a respectful form of address meaning "fellow practitioner" in Daoist usage. In martial fiction, it can be used more broadly.

Bow Saint silently joined her two curved swords into a massive bow. Everyone fell quiet.

Who were they?

The Fire King and the Bow Saint.

The King of Kings, who held the fiercest flames. The star of the martial world, who'd ruled countless battlefields with a single bow.

Living legends of Murim.

And—

Step.

I, too, had earned the right to stand with them. I had become a symbol in my own right, someone who could walk toward the Fire King and Bow Saint.

I might be a little smaller than they were, and weaker still.

I, Jin Taekyung—the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—was another giant who'd risen in this goddamn war.

Rrrrrumble!

The ground trembled. No, it writhed.

Apart from the low hill behind us, this reed bed had been open on every side. Now thick dust clouds surrounded it.

No—not dust clouds. Monsters we knew nothing about, from places we couldn't name.

But—

"Anyone still scared of those worthless bastards?"

I wasn't afraid of them.

The only thing I feared was someone dying because I'd made a mistake.

"If you're afraid—if you want to get away—leave the formation now. I won't blame you."

I meant it.

Everyone had family, something they had to protect. There was no cowardice in trying to survive.

If anyone wanted to fall back so they could make it home alive, I'd gladly protect them.

Just as someone had protected me years ago in that dark, reeking cave.

And now, beside me, were people worth risking my life to protect.

"Fuck it, what's life anyway? I've spent all this time following your ass around, Captain. Now I wouldn't even flinch if the Heavenly Demon's granddad showed up."

Hyuk Mujin's sudden remark drew quiet laughter from around us. Then he added, softly:

"I'll follow you. Even to the edge of hell."

"…!"

"…!"

For an instant, the air around us rang like a struck string.

The tremendous rumbling around us and the monsters' roars beyond it might as well have vanished. In their place rose a wave of steel.

Clang, clang, clang, clang!

Weapons lifted, and a shout went up.

The fighters forgot their exhaustion and their fear of monsters they'd never seen. They roared like beasts, glaring into the shifting darkness.

They remembered why they had to be here. They remembered the faces of those they missed, the people the monsters had killed.

And at their head stood me.

"Remember only two things."

I walked toward the vanguard as I spoke.

"First. Keep the formation, no matter what happens."

Clack, clack, clack!

A tide of people parted before me, revealing the empty space beyond.

Unlike the other sections, where a thousand men had gathered in each, this vacant spot looked like a massive hole that could collapse at any moment. But it wasn't one anymore.

"Second."

Step.

I stopped among the reeds.

Bow Saint stood to my left, Jeok Cheongang to my right. Behind the three of us stood the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion, who'd followed me as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

There were only a handful of us, but we filled the gap at the front. The formation was complete.

"Survive. Whatever it takes."

The instant I spoke those final words—

Rrrrrumble!

A deafening roar sounded as if the sky had split open, and countless shadows poured in from every direction.

Toward the circular formation of some three thousand elite fighters.

No. Toward an enormous wheel armed in steel.

Whoooosh—BOOM!

A streak of light flew from Bow Saint's fingertips, tore through the darkness, and exploded.

Craaaack!

The steel wheel—the wheel of death—met the monsters that did not belong in this world.

Jingle.

Beyond the swirling spray of blood, the eerie, sinister ringing of a bell carried through the air.

They were there in the deep darkness.

No. At least for now, perhaps they *were* the darkness.

They weren't merely hiding in it. They wore it like a curtain, concealing their bodies behind it. Even if they hadn't been covered head to toe in black, precious few people could have seen through that curtain.

The people capable of seeing through their concealment were hundreds of yards away, fighting countless monsters.

Monsters that, to be precise, were moving under the black-clad figures' control.

Jingle.

One of the figures shook the sinister bell in his hand.

The sound from the old, blackened bell was dull, yet it carried clearly into the distance, conveying another set of orders and information. His comrades, hidden at regular intervals on every side, were doing the same.

"So it's finally begun."

BOOM!

A flash lit up the distance with a tremendous boom, and the man muttered to himself.

The monsters' ceaseless roars made it impossible to tell much from sound alone. But that streak of light was unmistakably Bow Saint's. The battle had begun.

"It's not where we wanted them… Still, at least we managed to surround them."

He couldn't help feeling disappointed.

Fifteen minutes. If the enemy had moved just fifteen minutes faster and cleared the reed bed, he and his comrades could have begun the battle from a far more advantageous position.

"But it's started now. Nothing to be done."

The battle was underway, and the task assigned to the thirty sorcerers, himself included, was clear.

"Reduce their numbers as much as possible. If you can, capture Jin Taekyung alive."

He quietly repeated the order the Blood Lord had sent half a day earlier and frowned.

“Capture him alive? Not kill him?”

He’d received information on the enemy before the order arrived. It was absurd.

Their force included no fewer than six Supreme Peak masters. Two of them were the Fire King and Bow Saint.

If the sorcerers threw everything they had at Jin Taekyung alone, they might well kill him. Capturing him alive was another matter entirely.

“Damn it.”

The curse at the Blood Lord slipped out before he could stop it. He sucked in a breath and glanced around.

But, as always, there were only monsters standing vacantly nearby, reeking horribly.

“…This is bullshit.”

He glared at his subordinates. He hated the sight of himself trembling at the thought of the Blood Lord, who was far away. Today, the mindless monsters that did nothing but stink seemed especially loathsome too.

“Stupid things.”

Jingle.

The black-robed man shook the evil bell with a shooing motion. The hundred monsters surrounding their master to guard him immediately took a step back without hesitation.

At least, that was what the black-robed man knew was supposed to happen.

Step.

“…?”

He blinked.

Ninety-nine monsters had backed away. The remaining one had taken a step forward.

“What the hell is this?”

Before the black-robed man could find the words, the monster finally seemed to realize its situation. Its backside twitched as it fidgeted, then it said:

“W-Wow. Amazing. Never seen a monster like this before, have you?”

“…!”

“I-I haven’t either. Damn it.”

The monster—or, clearly, someone who was a person—continued in a trembling voice, then wore a miserable expression and sighed.

Chapter 1072

At that moment, only one thought ran through the black-robed man's mind.

Am I seeing things?

It was a reasonable question.

He was a sorcerer. An experienced one, and highly skilled.

He had neither internal energy measured in jiazi[3752] nor martial arts exceptional enough to be called divine. What he did have was the ability to control hundreds of monsters perfectly.

And yet…

What the hell is this guy?

He stared blankly at the monster before him—or rather, at the intruder who had clearly pulled a monster's hide over himself.

Only after pinching his arm hard enough to confirm he wasn't dreaming could he force out the question he'd been holding back.

"Who are you?"

The intruder flinched and answered haltingly.

"I-I'm a monster."

"…You're talking like a person."

"A-aren't there monsters that talk like people?"

"…There can't be."

Faced with the expert's thoroughly logical rebuttal, the intruder fell silent for a moment. Then he opened his mouth.

"Grrrooooar."

"…"

"Ahem. Grrrooooar."

"…"

"G-grraaaah."

Now he was even raising both arms like a jiangshi[3753] as he continued his uncertain attempts at a monster's roar. The black-robed man, more confused than ever, shouted, "Stop!"

The intruder gasped. "Why?"

"What the hell are you doing?"

"I was trying my best to imitate them… Wasn't that last one pretty close?"

"Well, the last one was a little close."

"Wow, I knew it! Thank you!"

[3752] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle used here to measure accumulated internal energy.

[3753] In Chinese folklore, a *jiangshi* is a reanimated corpse often depicted with stiff, outstretched arms.

An exchange that strayed this far from common sense could paralyze the mind.

As the black-robed man stood speechless, the intruder, unable to hide his delight, added proudly, “All that practice for two days straight paid off. I guess it’s true what they say: hard work doesn’t betray you.”

The black-robed man blinked, still floundering in confusion.

“W-what did you just say?”

“Hm?”

The intruder tilted his head. His eyes, visible beyond the rotten hide, were clear and bright.

“Oh, about hard work not betraying you? My grandfather’s been telling me that since I was little…”

“Not that!”

“Oh, I know what you mean. The big people. Well, it’s not quite right to call them people, but anyway, I hid in there and kept trying to imitate them.”

“S-so you mean…”

“That’s right. Like I said, I’ve been doing it for two days.”

“…!”

The answer was innocent enough, but the black-robed man felt a shock run down his spine.

For two days? And I never noticed?

It made no sense.

After grueling training, he’d gained the ability to control some five hundred monsters perfectly. He could detect the life energy of a living human with his eyes closed.

But…

He’s not lying.

He could feel it instinctively. Everything the intruder had said was true, without a single lie.

As far as he could tell, the man didn’t have the Intelligence to lie convincingly. And now that he’d been caught so plainly, he had no reason to hide anything.

That realization finally brought the black-robed man to his senses. Until now, he might as well have been bewitched.

“You… You’re an orthodox faction lackey.”

The intruder gasped and hurriedly waved his hands.

“N-no, I’m not!”

“Shut up, you madman.”

“Madman? That’s a very vulgar and bad word. My grandfather told me never to say it.”

“You little piece of—!”

The black-robed man felt his blood rush to his head. However unexpected the situation, he'd let this lunatic play him, if only for a moment.

He shook the evil bell in his hand, putting all his anger into the motion.

Jingle!

He hadn't imagined the extra force in its sound.

The death energy possessed by sorcerers who commanded monsters made the ringing clearer and more sinister. That chilling note carried two messages.

First, it alerted the other sorcerers stationed nearby to what was happening.

And second—

Whoosh! Thud!

It ordered the hundred or so monsters he'd brought as guards to deal with the madman.

"You have one chance left to receive my mercy."

The monsters swept around them with speed that belied their enormous frames, surrounding the intruder and forming an iron wall in front of the black-robed man. From behind it, he ground out his offer.

"Surrender quietly and tell me everything you know. I'll give you a relatively quick and painless death."

He wasn't relying on numbers alone.

Each monster guarding him had skill comparable to a master ranging from at least Supreme First Rate up to Peak.

Their strength and speed surpassed human limits, and, more than anything, their tenacious vitality was a nightmare.

And there were a hundred of them.

Even if the intruder before him was a lunatic with tremendous skill, the outcome wouldn't change in the slightest.

The monsters here weren't the only ones he'd have to face.

"Struggle all you like. In a few moments, you won't even be able to do that."

Thinking of his fellow sorcerers, who should have received the signal and be rushing here already, the black-robed man curled one corner of his mouth.

"But why haven't they answered?"

The intruder's sudden question made the black-robed man reflexively ask:

"What?"

"Answered. Uh, should I call it an answering ring? Anyway, I watched you for two days. You always send a bell signal back, even for the smallest thing."

"…Huh?"

The black-robed man suddenly realized something. He hurriedly looked around.

No. Looking would do him no good. He focused every bit of his attention on listening for his fellow sorcerers' reply—for the sinister ringing of bells like his own.

But all he heard was the wind blowing in from far away and the breathing of the monsters around him. No answer came.

Nothing at all.

"…!"

His heart lurched.

Something had gone wrong.

Terribly wrong.

As dread swept through him, his eyes turned toward the intruder. Despite being surrounded by monsters, the fellow had his ears pricked and his hands cupped around them like a trumpet, listening too.

"Oh. I definitely can't hear anything. Nothing at all."

"You… You…"

What could he say? How was he supposed to make sense of this?

The black-robed man could barely get the words out. Beyond the discolored monster hide, the intruder's eyes curved clearly into crescents.

"What a relief. I knew I could count on Little Grandpa."

"Little… Grandpa?"

"Yes. He teaches me all sorts of things. He gets really angry whenever I call him Little Grandpa, but sometimes I think he secretly likes it, too."

The intruder caught himself rambling and snapped his mouth shut with a gasp.

"Oh, don't tell Little Grandpa I said that. He'll get angry again."

The black-robed man didn't answer. He no longer had the presence of mind to.

He stared at the intruder, who had finally stopped talking, and barely managed to force out the question that had just come to him.

"Who… No, who are you people?"

His vision swam. What he'd just heard had made him realize a truth he desperately didn't want to believe.

The other thirty or so sorcerers who had come here with him were already dead.

They'd been killed the same way the intruder had slipped in beside him—or in a manner even more secretive and deadly.

If any were still alive, they wouldn't be for long.

Not if the man whose sobriquet had just flashed through the black-robed man's mind was here.

"Th-that Little Grandpa of yours… Don't tell me he's…"

"What did you just say?"

The flat voice suddenly pierced his ears, and a shock like lightning striking the crown of his head swept over him.

He was here.

Little Grandpa—no, *that man*.

Right behind him.

Yet the black-robed man hadn't sensed his breathing. No breath had brushed the back of his neck when the man spoke. He'd detected neither the slightest presence nor a trace of life energy.

The breathless voice sounded again in the black-robed man's ear. His body had gone rigid as a statue.

"I asked you. What were you babbling about?"

The black-robed man forgot how to speak. He even forgot how to breathe.

All he could do was make one final, instinctive struggle to survive.

He didn't even realize that a thin line had cut across his wrist before he could move the old, bloodstained evil bell, which was practically everything he had.

Slice. Plop.

Everything came a moment too late.

The severed wrist hit the ground. Only then did its owner notice it was gone.

And the black-robed man recognized the pain only when it arrived at last, then let out a scream filled with fear.

"Guh…!"

Tap. Thud.

His body crumpled helplessly as the Sleep Acupoint was pressed.

Unable even to finish his scream, he plunged into pitch-black darkness with no end in sight. The voices of two people drifted after him, faint as a dream.

"I told you I'd kill you if you called me that one more time."

"I'm sorry, Little Grandpa."

"…This is driving me crazy. Let's go find that guy."

"Yes! Little Grandpa!"

Truly, right to the very end, it was like a nightmare.

Chapter 1073

Slice!

The moment I brought my spear down and cut through its first victim, my heart sank.

Was it because the enemy was stronger than I'd expected?

Or because some part of me was already turning over the word *defeat*?

No. Neither was true.

I'd believed we would win from the start. I'd never doubted it.

I was simply facing my own limits again.

The limits of a mere human—limits I could never completely escape, no matter how many times I broke through them.

How many people will die this time?

Of course I knew I wasn't an all-powerful god who could save everyone. No one else could be one, either.

Not the heroes of distant myth. Not even Cheon Taemin, hailed as humanity's savior.

To gain something, you had to pay a fitting price. Whether that price was time or lives.

But knowing that didn't mean I could get used to it.

No. I must never get used to it.

If I did, I'd start taking it all for granted.

And another person's sacrifice and death must never become something I took for granted.

Crraaaack!

Just once.

The spearhead swept through, wreathed in Force. Flesh tore with a sickening sound, and a thick mist of blood spread through the air.

If the enemy had been human, the sight would have struck them with shock and fear.

But even as dozens of monsters were minced into chunks and scattered, they didn't so much as flinch. They surged in from every direction, a relentless tide.

Their tightly packed front line didn't match the savage force of their charge.

Their Intelligence isn't high enough for this. Someone's definitely directing them.

Before the battle had begun in earnest, the eerie sound of bells had carried on the wind from every direction. I hadn't imagined it.

Mutants, or monsters.

I didn't know exactly what to call those hideous creatures, but one thing was clear: somewhere, someone was controlling them like puppets.

There was just one problem…

They're well hidden.

Maybe they'd taken the presence of Supreme Peak masters like me into account. There had to be several of them, yet I couldn't find a single one.

Neither could the person with the sharpest eyes among our allies.

Whoosh—BOOM!

Four streaks of light flew in succession toward the east, west, north, and south, swallowing the space before them as they exploded.

Amid the shock waves and thunderous blasts that shook the air on every side, a familiar, calm voice reached my ears.

"I can't see or sense them from here. They're at least a hundred *jang*[3754] away."

Bow Saint had spoken as if she'd read my mind.

At the same moment, Jeok Cheongang appeared, drenched in the monsters' blood.

"And there are a hell of a lot of them."

Fwoosh—BOOM!

Before he'd even finished speaking, he thrust out a fist.

Flames raced forward, burning even the air, and swallowed the monsters in a blast of heat.

"Grrr…"

"Aaagh!"

Screams rang out one over another.

Yet even after that mighty strike brought down dozens more enemies, Jeok Cheongang's expression didn't brighten in the slightest.

"At this rate, it'll never end. Unless we wipe out every last one of them, we won't open a path."

The battle was going our way. That much was clear.

The problem was what would happen by the time we'd killed all the monsters surrounding us.

A substantial number of our three thousand allies would be dead or wounded, and Dark Heaven would keep pursuing us afterward.

Damn it.

I swallowed the curse rising in my throat and looked around.

The battle against ten thousand monsters had begun only moments ago.

For now, thanks to the efforts of several Supreme Peak masters, myself included, we hadn't suffered any notable casualties. But that was only a matter of time.

[3754] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred *jang* is about 303 m (994 ft); two *jang* is about 6.06 m (19.9 ft).

They were already exhausted. They'll crumble soon.

Battle was a fight against yourself, too.

Our fighters might be handpicked elites, but unlike the enemy, they were human, made of flesh and blood.

Once you knew you stood between life and death, your body tired quickly and your thoughts began to blur.

The Supreme Peak masters were giving everything they had from the start to protect them, and we were burning through our strength faster than usual.

I was no exception.

Thwack! Thud!

My spearhead cut cleanly through the tendon in a monster's calf. The hulking beast, a full two *jang*[3755] tall, dropped to one knee.

Its enormous frame looked nothing like a human's.

The flesh covering these monsters was as tough as leather armor. Cutting through their bones, which were harder still, took even more strength.

Crack.

I poured a good deal of internal energy into a palm strike and crushed its skull. Gritting my teeth, I shouted, "Hold the formation!"

The order was repeated all around me, but the replies had already grown noticeably quieter and weaker.

Something has to change.

Fear.

The darkest emotion humans were given.

Of course they were afraid. They were surrounded by monsters they'd never seen or heard of before.

And right now, I had the power to break fear's hold on them.

There was one move—our best chance to turn the situation around, even if it took a tremendous amount of strength.

One chance. Just one. I'll find an opening and tear through their line in a single strike.

Even the strongest wall would fall once you forced a gap in it.

I slowly drew in a breath.

The world began to slow. The noise around me faded, and a new sense opened deep within me.

The Middle Dantian. It still felt unfamiliar.

Rumble…

The space around me suddenly trembled.

[3755] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred *jang* is about 303 m (994 ft); two *jang* is about 6.06 m (19.9 ft).

I reached out, sensing everything around me.

Or tried to.

Right then, someone appeared, letting out a roar loud enough to shatter my intensely focused senses.

“Gaaaaal!”

His voice brimmed with resolve.

With movements far too impish to match it, Great Sir stepped in front of me and swung an iron sword back and forth. I had no idea where he’d found it.

“You foolish, pitiful monsters! Gaettong, a divine general descended upon this land by Heaven’s will, has arrived! Kneel at once!”

“…!”

“…!”

A cold silence fell.

My allies stared blankly at Great Sir. So did the monsters charging at us from every direction.

What the hell is this guy?

Same look. Same thought.

But the man who’d worked the miracle of bringing humans and monsters together in a moment of shared bewilderment carried on in a stern voice, undeterred.

“Hey! What are you waiting for? Can’t you hear Chunja’s command?”

At the Great Sir’s pronouncement, having changed not only his name but his gender, Jeok Cheongang muttered like a man sighing, “We should’ve grabbed that guy and killed him first.”

A perfectly reasonable suggestion. I almost nodded, but that wasn’t what mattered right now.

The Great Sir showing up at the vanguard meant there was a gap in the left wing, led by Sama Pyo. And that meant our entire formation might soon collapse.

That lunatic…!

I’d known he wasn’t in his right mind. I just hadn’t expected him to pull this shit at such a critical moment.

But there was no time to vent my anger.

I held back the stream of curses rising from deep in my chest and was about to send Great Sir back to his post when—

BOOM!

The ground shook with a tremendous rumble. The nearest monster suddenly dropped to one knee.

“What… What is this?”

The sound that escaped someone’s lips gave voice to the question on all our minds, mine included.

Before we could find an answer, the other monsters surrounding us like an iron wall began to tremble.

“Grrk. Grrrk.”

“Kuwo?”

Their pupils dilated. They let out groans none of us could understand.

And then it began.

Thud. Rumble!

The ground shook as heavy bodies fell one after another, raising thick clouds of dust.

Hundreds fell, then hundreds more, then hundreds again.

It went on until every monster filling the vast reed bed had collapsed.

They fell like an enormous line of dominoes. Everyone, including me, stood speechless before the impossible sight.

Everyone except one person.

“Mm. Yes, that’s right. You’re finally behaving yourselves.”

Great Sir turned toward me, muttering smugly.

“Ahem. Did you see that? That’s what I can do.”

Of course I’d seen it.

I’d seen it perfectly clearly, right in front of me.

And at that moment, I could manage only one question.

“…What is this? Am I dreaming?”

“A dream, you say? Well put. A person’s life is like a dream in broad daylight.”

Great Sir nodded with a knowing smile.

Over his shoulder, Jeok Cheongang looked at me, half dazed.

“What… What in the world is going on?”

As if I knew. I was just as dumbfounded.

“I have no idea either,” I answered.

“You don’t know?”

“No.”

“Well, I’ve seen all sorts of strange things. Have I lived too long?”

“You have lived a long time.”

“Or could we be having the same dream?”

“Maybe. If you don’t mind, could I hit you once? I think it’d hurt too much if you hit me.”

“That sounds far too much like your usual bullshit for a dream. Come to think of it, it’s been a while since you got hit, hasn’t it?”

“That’s a very realistic reaction. Definitely not a dream, then.”

I swiftly shifted my stance to avoid the misfortune of getting hit by Jeok Cheongang, and a voice reached my ears from far away.

“Those two never change. They really don’t.”

I paused. It sounded like a boy who hadn’t even gone through puberty.

“Wow! I’ve never seen a Master and Disciple like that before!”

The next voice came on the wind, bright and impossible to forget. My lips parted before I knew it.

“…Cheongpung?”

Chapter 1074

There's an old saying.

Those who meet must part; those who leave will surely return.

Every meeting ends in a farewell, and everyone who leaves will one day come back.

That old proverb came to mind as I stared wide-eyed at two figures approaching from far away, picking their way through the monsters strewn across the ground in the surrounding darkness.

"Over here! We're over here!"

"How many times do I have to tell you not to shout like that…? Never mind. Do whatever the hell you want."

"Yes! Thank you!"

"This is driving me insane."

The young man bounced along as if he had springs in the soles of his feet, while the boy beside him sighed like an old man. To some people, they might have made a strange sight.

But I—or, rather, a tiny handful of people including me—already knew who they were.

Especially the young man bouncing along in front. You could meet him only once and never forget his energy.

"…Cheongpung?"

The name slipped from my lips before I knew it. The people who'd been frozen in a daze since the monsters' bizarre collapse blinked.

"Cheongpung? Could it be…"

"T-the Huashan Divine Dragon?"

Their reaction was immediate.

There was only one Cheongpung I knew well enough to recognize at a glance who might turn up in a situation like this. You could turn the whole world upside down and shake it out without finding another.

Of course, someone raised a reasonable question.

"I can't see that far. Captain, are you sure you're not mistaken? Why would Cheongpung suddenly show up here…"

Hyuk Mujin had barely begun speaking in an uncharacteristically cautious tone when a clear voice rang out from beyond the darkness.

"Benefactooor!"

"…That's him."

"…It is."

"…Just hearing him makes my head spin. It's definitely him."

At this point, that voice was practically a fingerprint.

Hyuk Mujin and I confirmed it, and then Jeok Cheongang put the matter to rest.

“Benefactor! I’m here!”

With that final shout, Cheongpung swept in like a gust of wind and waved at me, his face flushed.

“Wow, it’s been so long! Have you been doing well?”

How was I supposed to respond to that?

I stared at the first-time-experience menace before me, half bewildered and half glad to see him. After a moment, I finally managed to speak.

“No. Not at all.”

“Oh. You do look that way, actually.”

“Then why’d you ask?”

“I haven’t been doing well, you see. But I hoped things might be different for you. Hee-hee.”

Cheongpung said something gloomy as cheerfully as ever. Watching him, I realized how to respond.

Or rather, a quiet laugh escaped me before I could help it.

“Wait, why are you laughing?”

“You call that a question? He’s laughing because the way you act is ridiculous, you little punk.”

That wasn’t my answer.

Swish.

A boy appeared from the darkness, his presence as faint as a ghost’s—or rather, the greatest assassin of all time. He stared straight at me and added:

“Though the one laughing is just as much of a reckless brat.”

His tone was as blunt as ever.

But when I saw the faint smile at the corner of his mouth, I could only laugh aloud instead of answering.

We’d met again after several months.

Reunions with people you’ve missed are always a joy.

But none of us was stupid enough to sit around a campfire chatting in a situation like this.

“We’d best get out of here quickly. Follow me.”

Before the warmth of our reunion had even faded, the Slaughter Saint wiped the smile from his face and got moving as if nothing had happened.

“Throw away anything that might slow us down. Especially that idiot over there.”

Jeong Hogun, the idiot the Slaughter Saint had pointed out, replied.

“I don’t know what sort of elder you are, but you should at least show some courtesy. I am a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, serving under His Majesty the Emperor’s solemn command…”

Whoosh.

It happened in an instant.

The Slaughter Saint’s figure blurred. Wind swept past, and a gleaming blue dagger came to rest against Jeong Hogun’s neck.

“Go on. Keep talking. Waste even a few more moments and I’ll make you a *late* elder.”

Everyone, myself included, recognized the extraordinary loyalty Jeong Hogun and his Embroidered Uniform Guards bore the Emperor.

But reality was cold.

The Emperor was somewhere far away. The dagger was right against Jeong Hogun’s neck. He stared at it for a moment, then spoke with a grim face.

“As I said, I am a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, serving under His Majesty the Emperor’s solemn command…but you appear to have a close relationship with the Marquis of Shangshan, so I’ll let this pass.”

The Slaughter Saint replied dryly to that thoroughly undignified excuse for an Embroidered Uniform Guard.

“We’re not that close.”

“You seem to know each other at least somewhat, so I’ll let it pass.”

“Of course we know each other. I said we’re not close.”

“…”

“Just let it go. Understand?”

“…”

“I’ll take that as a yes.”

The Slaughter Saint had let him keep that last scrap of dignity in the name of martial-world etiquette. By the time he put away the dagger, most of our three thousand allies were staring at him in shock.

A boy who couldn’t be twenty, even by the most generous estimate, had subdued a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard who had reached the far end of the Peak realm.

In a single move, so fast no one could see it.

Everyone was astonished, but Perfected Being Hyeoncheon seemed more shaken than anyone.

“Fellow Daoist…who are you?”

What you can see depends on where you stand.

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon was a seasoned Supreme Peak master, skilled enough to make out something of the Slaughter Saint's true realm. Shock and confusion left him unable to say more, and Bow Saint spoke in his place.

"It's been a long time. I never thought I'd see you again like this."

The Slaughter Saint had seen through her identity, just as she had his. He answered with a bitter smile.

"I feel the same. After that day, I thought we'd never meet again."

"Mountains and rivers have changed, and the world has changed with them. I had to act to set everything right."

The people around them looked more confused with every word they exchanged. Bow Saint quietly added:

"Just as you did, Slaughter Saint."

"…!"

"…!"

"…!"

For an instant, the air seemed to crackle.

The Slaughter Saint.

Once condemned by the whole martial world, he had gone on to strike fear into countless great fiends after the Great War between the Orthodox and Demonic factions began. He was the greatest assassin of all time.

Those two words were enough to explain the situation to everyone.

The Slaughter Saint gave Bow Saint a small nod, then addressed the people frozen like statues.

"So. Is there another idiot who wants to waste this precious time?"

Of course there wasn't.

Or, to be precise, even if there was, there had better not be.

Not when the person asking was the Slaughter Saint.

Clank. Clatter!

Jeong Hogun and the other Embroidered Uniform Guards threw off their armor with the speed of reservists heading home after training. The Slaughter Saint's eyes suddenly narrowed.

"But what exactly is that thing?"

I followed his gaze and immediately understood what he meant.

I also understood why he'd called a human being with all his limbs intact a *thing*.

"Well, how should I put it… That gentleman's a little out of his mind."

"…I've gathered that much."

The Slaughter Saint sighed as he watched Great Sir, who had somehow blended in among the Embroidered Uniform Guards and was enthusiastically stripping off his clothes.

“I’ll have to hear the details, but it seems clear enough that we’ve got one more madman.”

The original madman, of course, was watching the newcomer’s display of physical beauty from right beside him, full of admiration.

“Wow! I’ve never seen anyone take their clothes off so boldly!”

Jeong Hogun stopped Great Sir just as he was about to remove his underwear. Great Sir spotted Cheongpung, and his eyes lit up.

“Thank you for the compliment. And who might you be?”

“Hello! I’m Cheongpung!”

“You’re a spirited young man. I like that. I’m Soonja.”

“Nice to meet you, Auntie!”

No.

Are these guys seriously insane?

Just as everyone stood aghast at the meeting of two natural disasters that shouldn’t occur even once in a hundred years, the Slaughter Saint shook his head and spoke.

“Right. Let’s get going.”

In his hand was a rope that stretched far off into the distance.

“What’s that?”

“War trophy.”

To get straight to the point, the enemies didn’t pursue us after that.

Or maybe it would be more accurate to say that they did, and they didn’t.

“Go on ahead. I’ll catch up soon.”

The Slaughter Saint said that and left us several times. Each time he returned just when we needed him, his body reeking of blood.

After nearly two full days, he said, “They should be less of a nuisance from here on.”

Not one of our three thousand allies, myself included, failed to understand what he meant. He’d shaken off Dark Heaven’s relentless pursuit.

And we all knew how he’d dealt with the pursuers so quickly—and that it was he and Cheongpung, not Great Sir, who had taken down the nearly ten thousand monsters.

“Mmph, mmph.”

The war trophy—no, the black-robed man bound from head to toe in rope—wriggled. Taishan, who was running with him tucked under one arm like a piece of luggage, raised a fist as big as a cauldron lid.

“Don’t move. I’ll hit you.”

“Mmph. Mmmph!”

“Don’t make noise. I’ll eat you.”

“…!”

It was a strange threat, but it worked perfectly.

The black-robed man went still and silent as a mouse. Our allies had been on a brutal forced march for days without rest, but before long we finally left that miserable wilderness behind.

Waiting for us was an enormous lake unlike any I’d ever seen. Around it, a group of beggars huddled together beside their campfires.

Among them was a very familiar face.

“Oh! They’re here! Over here!”

A face so shabby it made you reach for your wallet even from a distance.

Gung Gibang—the next beggar king, destined to lead a hundred thousand beggars.

Chapter 1075

Sometimes people you've been meaning to see all come back into your life at once.

Like right now.

"I'm Gung Gibang, a junior of Murim. It's an honor to meet you, Seniors!"

Gung Gibang had come running as if his feet were on fire. At his hearty greeting, I spoke on everyone's behalf in a stern voice.

"The Beggars' Sect's Successor Beggar, is it? Good. Pleased to meet you."

"…"

"I'm Jin Taekyung. We're about the same age, so from now on, feel free to call me Elder."

"…You haven't changed. Not one bit."

I shrugged at the guy, whose already ugly face looked like he'd just swallowed shit.

"Of course I haven't. If a perfectly normal person suddenly changes, it means he's about to die."

"I don't think you were ever perfectly normal."

"I was a lot better than you."

"In what way, exactly?"

"Plenty of ways. Let's start with our looks. We're on completely different levels."

"Damn it. I can't deny that one."

Gung Gibang let out a deep sigh, then chuckled.

"Still, I'm glad you haven't changed."

I laughed along with him.

It felt good to hear him say that. And I felt the same way about him.

Gung Gibang and the Beggars' Sect disciples led us over to the campfires.

A winter-cold blizzard was howling all around us, but the warmth of the fires springing up here and there was enough to make us forget the cold. They'd also laid out dry rations to replenish our exhausted allies' hunger and strength.

Plenty of them.

"Were you waiting for us?"

"Of course. We expected reinforcements to come from Gansu."

Gung Gibang handed me some jerky and added, "We even figured those reinforcements might make the insane choice of crossing the Qilian Mountains."

"Was it a rash decision? The missive from the Kunlun Sect made it sound like there wasn't an hour to spare."

“No. It was exactly the right call. We only got a chance to catch our breath a few days ago ourselves.”

A scab still marked Gung Gibang’s forehead, proof enough that he wasn’t lying.

A clear mark of battle.

His expression and voice were bright, but he’d recently been through a fight for his life, too.

“Oh, this? It’s nothing. Don’t worry about it. I survived, and that’s what matters.”

Gung Gibang gave me a bitter smile, doing his best to sound solemn. I looked him up and down.

“Yeah. It really is nothing.”

“…”

“What?”

“Could you let me hit you just once?”

“Hmm. If you ask nicely, maybe.”

“And what about revenge afterward?”

“Oh, come on. What do you take me for? Of course there’ll be revenge. I’ll beat you within an inch of your life.”

“…I had you pegged perfectly.”

Gung Gibang shook his head and went on. “Anyway, considering we stayed at the very rear until the end, we got off cheap. Though that was only thanks to help arriving at just the right time.”

Gung Gibang glanced toward the Slaughter Saint, who’d been chewing his jerky in silence.

“You were just lucky,” the Slaughter Saint said. “We happened to be nearby.”

“I was truly shocked at first. I never imagined you’d be in Qinghai with Cheongpung…”

“The more people who know about you, the harder it is to accomplish your goal. And I’m no Great Hero.”

In other words, he’d kept his existence hidden even from his own allies.

“Then had you been here the whole time since we left for the Nanman Beast Palace?” I asked.

“I wouldn’t say the whole time. We only arrived in Qinghai about a month ago.”

I thought back over the past few months.

The last time I’d seen the Slaughter Saint was just after the Two Dragons Pavilion was founded, with Cheongpung and me at its center, around the time we left for Nanman.

So even setting aside that month in Qinghai, he’d spent the past several months on some kind of mission with Cheongpung…

Why hadn’t I heard a single thing about it?

It was strange.

Since we'd parted, I'd been caught up in one major incident after another, starting with the Nanman Beast Palace. Each time, the whole world's attention had turned our way.

Rumors traveled tens of thousands of ri[3756] without needing legs.

And yet I hadn't heard anything about where the Slaughter Saint and Cheongpung had been or what they'd done.

The Slaughter Saint clearly didn't want to tell me, either. Before I could ask, he spat out the jerky he'd been chewing.

"Tough. I'll be resting nearby for a bit. Don't look for me."

He hadn't said anything directly, but his actions made his meaning clearer than words.

"Always keeping secrets," Jeok Cheongang muttered, clicking his tongue as he watched the Slaughter Saint walk away. "No wonder people say he's got a foul temper."

Then he saw my expression and frowned.

"What's with that rotten look?"

"…What did I do?"

"Explain yourself."

"N-nothing. You probably know better than I do."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

Cheongpung, sitting near the campfire with a drowsy expression, spoke up on my behalf.

"Obviously, it means Grandpa Jeok's temper is just as foul, doesn't it, Benefactor?"

"…"

"Huh? Am I wrong?"

Of course he was right.

But some uncomfortable truths couldn't be said out loud. Especially when doing so might get you beaten to death.

Cheongpung, you little shit…

I stared at him with a dead-eyed look. He'd been gone a while, but apparently he'd learned a new assassination technique from the Slaughter Saint. I did my best to ignore Jeok Cheongang's scorching gaze beside me and changed the subject.

"So, Cheongpung, where have you been and what have you been doing for the past few months?"

"Hmm. Little Grandpa told me not to say."

"You can tell me."

[3756] A Korean *ri* is approximately 393 m (0.244 mi).

“He knew you’d say that. He told me not to say anything even if it was you, Benefactor.”

“I’m telling you, it’s fine. If you’re worried, just whisper it to me with Sound Transmission…”

“Wow, that’s amazing. He even told me to keep quiet if you tried to talk me into telling you by Sound Transmission.”

“…”

“He said he’d kill me if I said anything. I think I’ve heard ‘Silencing the Witnesses’ about five thousand times by now.”

“…Then I won’t ask.”

Of course, the Slaughter Saint wouldn’t try to silence the witnesses just because Cheongpung told me everything that had happened so far. But at this point, it would be polite not to press him further.

Well.

To be honest, I was also a little scared he really might try to silence the witnesses.

“What about what happened in Qinghai? Is that a secret, too?”

“No. He didn’t say anything about that, so I think it’s fine.”

Cheongpung answered innocently and gave us a rough account of the past month.

He started with why they’d slipped into Qinghai without telling anyone, and what they’d come to do.

“You were looking for spies who might already be inside?”

“Yes. Little Grandpa said a traitor at your back is scarier than an enemy right in front of you.”

He was right.

I’d learned that the hard way more than once. I couldn’t take those words lightly.

“So, did you find any spies?” Jeok Cheongang asked.

“No. At least, not as far as we could tell.”

If Cheongpung had been on his own, I might’ve checked his work a hundred times and still had my doubts. But if the Slaughter Saint was part of that *we*, I could trust it.

He wouldn’t have been called the greatest assassin of all time if he weren’t that thorough.

Still…

“It’s too soon to relax,” Jeok Cheongang said. “You never know what might happen in Murim.”

Spoken like a veteran of the martial world. Cheongpung nodded.

“That’s right. Little Grandpa thought so, too. So he was going to infiltrate the Kunlun Sect and investigate further.”

There was a big difference between *was going to* and *did*.

And I already knew what had stopped him.

“Dark Heaven attacked just then. Right?”

“Yes. It happened in an instant.”

They had an overwhelming advantage in numbers and strength.

Some of Qinghai’s martial artists, including those of the Kunlun Sect, immediately withdrew from the sect’s headquarters and retreated east. But the Slaughter Saint and Cheongpung stayed.

“We hid among them and waited for the right moment.”

Anyone else who’d tried that would have been discovered and killed long ago.

But the Slaughter Saint was an exception.

And so was the other person who’d spent the past several months learning from him.

“I held my breath and hid my presence, just like Little Grandpa taught me. No one noticed. Like this.”

As soon as he finished speaking, Cheongpung stopped breathing with a sharp *hup*. Instead of answering, I let out a hollow laugh.

Not because of how ridiculous he looked, but because his presence had faded to a ghostly blur, even though he was right in front of me.

Can he really do that? After only a few months?

I’d known the answer for a long time.

Yes—if it was Cheongpung.

With that insane talent of his, as if he didn’t need a System at all, he could learn even a concealment technique that difficult in no time.

With talent like that and the Slaughter Saint teaching him, of course they could avoid being noticed.

A first-rate teacher and a heaven-sent genius.

Together, they’d managed to infiltrate the enemy.

Of course, even they had their limits.

“I did my best, but unfortunately, I couldn’t get as far as Taiqing Hall.”

“Taiqing Hall…?”

“It’s on the highest peak of Kunlun Mountain. It’s where the Kunlun Sect decides everything, big and small. But there was a strange energy surrounding the area.”

Cheongpung shuddered, as if remembering how it had felt.

“I could feel something… something invisible and sticky. It gave me chills.”

“Sticky? And it gave you chills?”

“Yes. Enough to make me shudder. Little Grandpa must have felt it too, because he decided we should blend in with the monsters coming down the mountain just then and turn back. A few days later, we met you, Benefactor.”

Even after he finished, Cheongpung’s expression didn’t improve. I watched him with a deep, steady gaze and quietly turned over the two words that had come to mind the moment I heard his story.

Magical power.

And at that very moment—

Splash!

A gentle ripple spread across the broad blue river beyond the thick veil of fog.

Chapter 1076

The river there was blue, and as wide as the sea.

Perhaps that was why.

Over a span of time stretching back beyond anyone's memory, an unnamed freshwater lake had grown ever larger. Then, one day, people began calling it Qinghai Lake.

At this very moment, a shadow was crossing the blue waters of Qinghai Lake.

Splash.

A dozen or so oars pushed through the water in smooth, perfect unison.

Gentle ripples spread in their wake. The thick mist parted, revealing the shape it had concealed.

Sleek, streamlined curves.

A hull that was not especially large, but built of sturdy wood and reinforced with steel.

A sail billowing in the wind—and, seated cross-legged in perfect calm atop a mast so narrow no one would dare set foot on it, an old man.

"What a tailwind. Couldn't ask for better."

At the old man's voice overhead, the middle-aged man standing at the bow, gazing beyond the mist, answered.

"The days ahead will be the same."

"Even though we've already lost our sect's headquarters?"

"We didn't lose it. We gave it up to save precious lives."

The middle-aged man continued steadily.

"Someone I respect once told me that what matters isn't the house, but the people. A house where no one lives becomes an abandoned ruin. But where there are people, they can build a palace even on an empty plain."

"I don't know who told you that, but he must be an old man who talks a fine game and has nothing to show for it."

"M-Master. How could you say that? I didn't mean—"

"Ha ha. I know. I'm teasing."

The old man, who had just called himself all talk and no substance, smiled at his flustered Disciple and went on.

"So the days ahead will carry us along like a tailwind… I could ask for nothing more, if only that were possible. But the headwind we've faced has been so fierce. What are we to do?"

The middle-aged man shook his head at his Master's teasing, then answered firmly.

"No matter how fierce the wind is, it can't overturn a mountain instead of a ship."

"You're right. But what if that fierce wind carries an ember?"

"…!"

"The wind isn't what we should fear. It's a single ember hidden somewhere deep in the mountains, where no one knows to look. Before long, it might turn everything to ash."

The middle-aged man pondered the meaning of his Master's words. Then his expression tightened.

Master. Do you mean…?

A line of Sound Transmission slipped between his trembling lips.

But before he could hear the answer, the old man slowly rose and murmured:

"Even so, there should be a chance to fight fire with fire."

At that moment—

Whoosh.

Beyond the mist as it scattered in all directions, hundreds of campfires lined the banks of Qinghai Lake, reflected in the old man's gray-white eyes.

The sparks drifting on the wind were sparks of hope against the coming disaster.

The moment a sleek ship appeared through the mist, I knew who they were.

Or, more precisely, I recognized the old man gazing down at the shore from atop its towering mast.

Whoosh.

The sides of his robe spread and fluttered like wings.

He soared like a bird, crossed dozens of jang[3757] through the air, and began to descend. Cries of astonishment rose all around us.

"Th-that's…"

"Stepping on Empty Air…!"

Stepping on Empty Air was a supreme lightness skill that required several jiazi[3758] of internal energy and deep enlightenment.

These people had fought a desperate battle against monsters they'd never seen or heard of until two days ago. But that hadn't made them any less awed by the highest martial arts.

I, however, saw it a little differently.

"Now that's a remarkable display of Stepping on Empty Air. Don't you think so, too?"

At Jeok Cheongang's probing question, I clicked my tongue.

[3757] One jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3758] A jiazi is a sixty-year cycle in the traditional East Asian calendar.

"Do I look like an idiot to you?"

"What kind of rude answer is that?"

"You already know what I mean."

"…Hm. So you're not completely blind, after all."

I couldn't tell whether he was displeased that I hadn't played along or pleased by the progress I'd made. Jeok Cheongang murmured and gazed into the air.

"Still, when it comes to lightness skills, he's pretty good."

I let out a quiet laugh.

Coming from Jeok Cheongang, that was extraordinary praise. But it still fell short of the lightness skill the old man was displaying as he slowly descended.

If you call Gliding Across the Void "pretty good," every martial artist who's learned a lightness skill should bite their tongue and die.

There's always another sky above the sky.

Those whose knowledge of martial arts was shallow, or who had no place in Murim, considered Stepping on Empty Air the pinnacle. But there was a realm beyond it.

Not stepping on the air or kicking off it, but moving through it as naturally as if gliding. That was Gliding Across the Void. Only a handful of Supreme Peak masters, myself included, could recognize the difference. I could see it in the old man's feet.

And in the past hundred years, only two people have reached the realm of Gliding Across the Void.

Jeok Cheongang had told me about them while I was training on Mount Jiuhua.

One had eventually come to be called a god. The other had returned to where he belonged.

To a land far to the west, to the vast slopes of a mountain that touched the sky.

Swish.

At last, his toes touched the ground without a sound, and his robes settled around him.

The kindly-looking old man clasped his hands in greeting to everyone.

"I am Cheongheoja of the Kunlun Sect. My greetings to all my fellow Daoists."

"…!"

"…!"

An invisible wave of emotion swept through the crowd.

The old man who had appeared so suddenly with such astonishing skill was none other than the Sect Leader of the Kunlun Sect.

"W-We greet the Sect Leader!"

Urgent cries rose all around, accompanied by clasped-fist bows.

But, as always, there were exceptions.

“Fellow Daoist, my ass. You’ve gotten older and now you think you can treat this old man as an equal?”

That curt greeting from Murim’s veteran drill sergeant and the bane of every prestigious sect was only the beginning.

“It’s been a long time, Cheongheoja. You’ve got a lot more gray hair now. The last time I saw you, you still looked fairly young.”

Over the shoulder of the bow-wielding lady, who was at least from a respectable family and had bothered to use polite speech, a human butcher appeared—the man who’d become the greatest of all time through his skill at cutting people down.

“I thought you looked familiar. So you ended up becoming Sect Leader?”

“…”

“…”

The commotion over the Kunlun Sect Leader’s arrival died at once.

The Slaughter Saint, the Bow Saint, and the Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

What an insane lineup. Just looking at them was enough to take your breath away.

They might look middle-aged, mature, and boyish, respectively, but with the amount of time they’d spent in Murim, they could perform the miracle of feeding five thousand with five loaves and two fish.[3759]

And Cheongheoja’s ordeal wasn’t over.

“Mm. This humble Daoist is late in greeting you. How have you been all this—”

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, the Sect Leader of the Kongtong Sect, had hesitated at the arrival of those martial-world veterans. He had only just managed to speak when—

“Hello, Grandpa Cheongheoja! I’m Cheongpung! We both have the surname Cheong, so I hope we get along from now on!”

“I am Soonja. We don’t share a surname, but the last syllable of our names is the same. Let’s get along well enough.”

“Taishan hungry. Did you catch any meat on your way here?”

A different kind of insane lineup.

Pure, unfiltered madness.

The arrival of that hopeless trio, every bit as disastrous as the Three Saints, made my vision dim. Yet, to my surprise, Cheongheoja chuckled.

“Some respected Seniors, and some juniors I’m meeting for the first time. It’s a pleasure to meet you all again.”

At that moment, I had a thought.

Maybe the greatest sect under heaven was the Kunlun Sect.

“…Wow. He actually put up with that.”

[3759] The feeding of the five thousand is a miracle recounted in the Christian Gospels.

The exclamation slipped from my lips before I could stop it, and Cheongheoja turned his gaze toward me.

“This is the first time I’ve seen you up close. It’s good to meet you, Fellow Daoist Jin.”

As he’d said, I’d seen him before, though only from a distance.

And our connection went a little deeper than simply having crossed paths. During the Star-Array Grand Banquet, Hak Woo—the Kunlun Cloud Dragon—had spent some time with Gung Gibang and the others. He was Cheongheoja’s Disciple.

“I greet the Sect Leader.”

I belatedly clasped my hands in a formal bow. Cheongheoja nodded with a warm smile.

“It’s been a long time. I’ve heard a great deal about you since then. That boy Hak Woo was especially fond of you.”

“Um, by any chance…”

As if he’d seen through the question I couldn’t quite bring myself to finish, Cheongheoja answered gently.

“He’s doing well. You needn’t worry.”

“That’s a relief.”

I couldn’t say I’d known Hak Woo for long, but the guy I knew was a good one.

As a martial artist, and as a person.

So I was genuinely glad to hear what Cheongheoja said next.

“You’ll see him soon. Once we’ve left this place.”

“I see.”

I already knew Qinghai Lake wasn’t our home base. Gung Gibang and the Beggars’ Sect disciples had simply come ahead to meet us; the threat from Dark Heaven hadn’t disappeared completely.

But Cheongheoja’s words did raise one question…

“Even so, the boat seems a little, well… pretty small.”

I looked dubiously at the ship, which had nearly reached the shore.

It looked like it could hold a hundred people at most—nowhere near enough to carry our three thousand allies.

“Does it look that way to you, too?”

“Sorry, but yes.”

“Ha ha.”

Cheongheoja laughed aloud at my honest answer, then spoke again.

“I suppose it might. From what you can see now.”

“Pardon?”

“Ah, there they are at last.”

I followed Cheongheoja’s gaze. So did everyone else.

Splash.

Only then did we see dozens of ships emerge through the thick mist.

Chapter 1077

Around noon, a group of black-clad men appeared atop a low hill.

Swish.

Pat, pat, pat!

At a casual wave from the man in front, several dozen of them scattered across the area to investigate what had happened here and deal with the aftermath.

“So someone got here before us.”

The man murmured to himself as he looked down the hill at the vast reed beds stretching for more than ten li[3760] in every direction—and the countless birds filling the gaps between them with black.

“They must have been hungry. It can’t have been an easy journey.”

Qinghai Lake, a few days’ travel from here, was a haven for migratory birds. Reaching it meant beating their wings without rest for a thousand li[3761], but enormous numbers came each year for its clean water and abundant food.

Of course, that was all in the past now.

Whoooosh.

A wind carrying a biting chill suddenly swept through the reeds. The migratory birds, busy filling their empty stomachs, shivered.

The cold was far too severe to be explained by the high elevation alone. At noon, when the sun should have been at its highest, black clouds covered the sky. Untimely frost had frozen the reed beds solid.

And these inexplicable changes, as though the seasons had forgotten their place, had been going on for more than a day or two.

Temperatures had fallen, and bitter cold raged day and night. Without enough sunlight, the plants had lost their former lushness. Elsewhere, severe drought had struck. It seemed the work of heaven’s whims or some supernatural power—especially when all of it had happened in little more than a year.

But Ma Sanbao saw things differently.

Crunch, crunch.

Frost broke beneath his feet as he slowly descended the hill. His thoughts deepened with each footprint he left behind.

This is no mere supernatural trick. His power borders on that of a heavenly god.

Heaven itself. An all-knowing, all-powerful god.

[3760] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi). Ten li are about 5 km (3.1 mi); a thousand li are about 500 km (311 mi).

[3761] A Chinese *li* is 500 m (0.311 mi). Ten li are about 5 km (3.1 mi); a thousand li are about 500 km (311 mi).

Thinking of his master, the Lord of Heaven, Ma Sanbao felt fear and reverence rise from the depths of his heart. Here was a being who could threaten the whole world, change the climate, and even bring the dead back to life.

Could someone like that truly be called human?

And why had he shared a portion of that unbelievable power with Ma Sanbao, who had abandoned even his own master—a man who had served the Lord of Heaven—and fled?

No. I'm different from my Master. I can be of far greater use to him in every way.

Ma Sanbao repeated the words to himself. The Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, whom he had served as Master all his life, had met a weak end. Ma Sanbao would not.

He would contribute greatly to the Lord of Heaven's grand design, and rule over a part of this world as his new servant.

Caw.

Snapping out of his thoughts, Ma Sanbao noticed countless pairs of eyes glinting at him and gave a quiet laugh.

"Looks like I've interrupted your meal. Don't mind me. Go on and finish."

His kind words made no difference. The birds covering the reed beds greeted their unexpected visitor with sharp cries, their bloodshot eyes flashing.

The killing intent in those eyes was far too intense to belong to ordinary birds.

"Well, the changes have already begun."

Clicking his tongue, Ma Sanbao studied them with interest.

Their beaks were smeared with blood. Their feathers and claws had grown thick and sharp, like those of predators. Beneath them lay the dishes that made up this lavish feast, giving off a stench of death as horrifying as the sight of them.

"Really, that instinct of yours is the problem."

It wasn't hard to work out what had happened.

The changing climate had frozen the plants to death, and the beasts and insects had long since disappeared. Unable to find food, countless migratory birds must have left Qinghai Lake and wandered the surrounding area. Some had finally found a meal in these nearby reed beds: the blood and flesh of monsters lying there like puppets with their strings cut.

"I needed to replenish my forces anyway. This worked out nicely."

Ma Sanbao smiled at the birds as they began to mutate.

Lately, some lunatic called the Great Sir had been knocking his birds out of the sky wherever he found them, making it difficult to keep watch. This many new birds was an unexpected windfall.

Cawww!

First, though, he would have to imprint the birds, now savage from eating cursed blood and flesh.

"All right. From now on, I'm your master."

Jingle.

The moment Ma Sanbao shook the ritual bell in his hand—

Whoooosh!

The countless birds hurtling toward him on beating wings changed course at once and shot high into the sky, obeying the bell's dull, eerie chime.

And the birds weren't the only ones to respond.

Shrrk. Rumble.

Bent knees straightened. Rigid backs unbent. Finally, tightly shut eyes opened halfway.

"More of them survived than I expected."

As Ma Sanbao murmured, watching the monsters rise to their full height throughout the broad reed beds, the black-clad men who had gone off earlier returned to report.

"We've checked everything."

"What did you find?"

One of the men respectfully held out something he was carrying.

Part of its face had been pecked away by birds. Otherwise, it looked just as it had in life, its perfectly natural expression frozen in place.

It was someone's head. Until a few days ago, the man had been Ma Sanbao's subordinate and their comrade.

"Most of them were in this condition."

"This…"

Ma Sanbao's eyes widened as he examined the head.

He was a sorcerer, but his martial skill had also reached Supreme Peak. Even so, the sword mark left on the head was so faint that it sent a chill down his spine.

"…A killing sword. One honed to its utmost."

"What does that mean?"

"There's a man called No Shadow. The Great Nation's imperial household raised him as its finest assassin. He guarded the Son of Heaven from the shadows, and even the East Depot I once served couldn't determine his true identity."

But even No Shadow couldn't leave a sword mark like this.

Ma Sanbao knew that well. Through relentless investigation and pursuit, he had once obtained the body of someone No Shadow had killed.

Now another man came to mind: a lame old man Jin Taekyung had killed during the bloodbath at the Grand Banquet a few months earlier.

Gye Yabu.

The last heir of Salcheonmun, the greatest assassin sect in the world, long believed to have vanished.

Why had he come to mind now?

Ma Sanbao soon found the answer.

“The Slaughter Saint…”

Yes. His presence explained everything.

Why not a single human corpse remained in these vast reed beds, where a fierce battle must have taken place. And why so many monsters had avoided a second death, even though the sorcerers had been eliminated.

“He finished it quickly. He knew exactly where we were vulnerable.”

Muttering to himself, Ma Sanbao flung his subordinate’s head far away.

The power bestowed on him by the Lord of Heaven allowed him to raise the dead, but not without limit.

“We’re leaving. By now, they must have left Qinghai Lake. We’ll hurry back and carry out the next order.”

The damage was done. At least they had recovered a considerable number of their forces and gained new subordinates. Ma Sanbao put his regret aside and turned to leave.

Or rather, he was about to.

“However…”

One of the black-clad men spoke up hesitantly.

“One man. Just one man is missing.”

“What?”

“We found a mutilated wrist, but no body anywhere.”

“Then…”

“It seems they captured him alive.”

“…!”

Ma Sanbao’s face twisted before he could stop himself.

After all his warnings to be careful, the man hadn’t even died. He’d been captured.

But his anger and agitation lasted only a moment. They had lost some valuable subordinates, and one had been taken alive, but those men were only minor branches of a much greater whole. Ma Sanbao hadn’t entrusted them with much information.

What bothered him a little was what his subordinate said next.

“The ritual bells they were carrying are gone, too. Every last one.”

“…What are they, thieves? They made sure to take everything.”

Ma Sanbao frowned, thought for a moment, then shook his head.

“No need to worry. Even with the bells, they can’t do anything.”

A country bumpkin couldn't become a Supreme Peak master overnight just by getting hold of a divine weapon. Likewise, using the bells properly required extensive training.

"Besides, even if the man they captured betrays us, he can command only a few hundred."

"That's impossible. We know him. He's loyal to the Heavenly Court, yes, but more than that, he's simply not the sort of man who could betray anyone…"

Seeing his subordinates defend their captured comrade, Ma Sanbao let out an involuntary laugh.

"He will."

"Pardon?"

"He will betray us. No—they'll make sure he does."

Ma Sanbao added quietly, "If that son of a bitch I know is involved, they will."

The face of that *son of a bitch* flashed before his eyes, and he reflexively reached inside his robe.

He remembered the note Jin Taekyung had handed him a few months earlier, pretending it was an important secret letter to deceive him. More precisely, he remembered the mysterious symbols written on it—symbols that even Ma Sanbao, for all his learning, couldn't decipher.

—You fucking dumbass lol

Still unable to make sense of them, Ma Sanbao ground his teeth.

Just wait. I'll pay you back soon.

His gaze, fixed on the east, seemed to be directed at someone crossing Qinghai Lake.

Chapter 1078

Qinghai Lake was like a small sea, just as its name suggested.

It was more than ten jang[3762] deep and stretched for thousands of li.[3763]

Without the ships, our allies—who'd even abandoned their horses on the way to Qinghai—would have had to walk for days and nights. But the dozens of ships that arrived after Cheongheoja, the Sect Leader of the Kunlun Sect, could easily carry all three thousand of us.

Shhhhh!

A bow carved with the shape of a cloud sliced through the water.

I was silently watching the lake, where the bitter cold had left thin ice in places, when a voice reached my ears.

"Isn't it strange? Winter is still a long way off, yet we're already seeing this."

I turned to find a sturdy-looking middle-aged Daoist. His face and voice were still unfamiliar, but we'd exchanged a brief greeting when I boarded the ship yesterday. I had no trouble remembering his Daoist name.

"Oh, Perfected One[3764] Hakso."

The Daoist's smile turned awkward.

"It's Hak Su. Not Hakso."

"…"

"…"

The silence grew awkward fast. After a moment, I forced myself to speak.

"Uh, did you happen to change your Daoist name recently?"

"No. Not once since I joined Kunlun."

"Then how long ago did you join?"

"Certainly not yesterday. It's been over forty years."

"I see."

"Yes."

No trouble remembering, my ass.

With nothing left to say, I looked up at the sky. "Uh, well. Nice weather."

Rumble, crash!

Thunder and lightning suddenly broke out overhead. Hakso—no, Hak Su—glanced at the sky and answered uncertainly.

"You must like stormy weather."

"…Of course. I don't just like it—I'm crazy about it."

[3762] A jang is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft); ten jang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

[3763] The Korean ri is a traditional distance of about 393 m (0.244 mi).

[3764] Perfected One is an honorific for an accomplished Daoist.

I'm going to lose my mind.

It was far too late to take any of it back. I stared at the dark sky, knowing I'd screwed up, and Hak Su let out a quiet laugh.

"I understand. It happens now and then. Not so often that it particularly stands out."

At that generous response, befitting a Daoist of the Kunlun Sect, I swallowed back tears and bowed my head.

"…I'm sorry."

"There's no need to apologize. We've known each other for only half a day. It's an easy mistake to make. Besides, Fellow Daoist Jin, you have a great responsibility on your shoulders."

Hak Su laughed heartily, but I'd still been rude. All the more so because the man standing before me was Cheongheoja's Senior Disciple and might one day succeed him as Sect Leader of Kunlun.

"I've often heard about you, so I know what sort of person you are. Just as the third one said, you're a very amusing man."

"By the third one, you mean…"

"You've guessed correctly. Hak Woo, the Kunlun Cloud Dragon. He's my youngest Junior Brother. Though given our ages, he's closer to being my Disciple."

Hak Su looked well past forty and nearly fifty, old enough that no one would have found it strange if Hak Woo, who wasn't yet thirty, had been his Disciple. In fact, they were fellow Disciples of the same Master, Cheongheoja.

"In any case, I've wanted to meet you for a long time. It's deeply unfortunate that we've met under these circumstances…but you came all this way to save our sect. Nothing could make me happier."

Caught off guard by Hak Su's praise, I scratched my head. I'd heard thanks like this before, but I had no desire to act the hero, as though I were somebody important.

Besides, the real battle hasn't even begun.

Of course, the allies about to gather in one place were stronger than any force I'd ever seen. Two of the Three Saints had joined us, and the Fire King Jeok Cheongang—a master who could hold his own against them—was with us too.

If several other Supreme Peak masters, myself included, and our handpicked three thousand elites joined the main force, we might even have the upper hand against Dark Heaven's massive army invading Qinghai.

But…

No one knows how things will unfold from here.

I couldn't get an exact count, but as far as I could tell, Dark Heaven's forces numbered close to a hundred thousand. Every last one was a monster, little different from the undead, with physical abilities far beyond those of a human.

That alone was a serious complication. But something else had been weighing on me with fear for some time now.

The Lord of Heaven.

An absolute being lurking beyond an abyss whose depths I couldn't fathom, swallowing the world—heaven and earth alike.

I couldn't even imagine what would happen if that bastard appeared before us soon.

There's a good chance the Lord of Heaven will enter this battle. Dark Heaven can't afford to back down.

Four Demon Lords and a Demon Empress, who'd been like his own limbs, had already fallen to my hand, and we'd inflicted heavy losses on his forces along the way.

If the Lord of Heaven lost an army of a hundred thousand in Qinghai as well, the blow would be enormous, even for him.

And yet, one thing still bothered me.

Then why make such an absurd choice in Gansu?

I bit my lip and recalled the Grand Sorceress's words.

Get stronger. Even stronger than you are now.

She'd let me live instead of killing me when my life hung by a thread.

No.

What I remembered was the intent of whoever had given her that order.

The Lord of Heaven doesn't want me—Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon—to die.

The truth I'd realized on that snowfield, covered in blood and corpses, dug through my mind like a sharp awl, leaving questions I couldn't answer and suspicions I could scarcely believe.

Maybe. Maybe the Lord of Heaven's real purpose is…

A headache struck without warning. I barely swallowed the groan rising in my throat.

"…Fellow Daoist? Fellow Daoist Jin, are you all right?"

A voice broke through my thoughts. Hak Su was watching me with concern.

"Are you feeling unwell? Your face…"

As he trailed off, I reflexively looked down at the water. A rigid face stared back from the clear surface, then broke apart as the bow carried us forward.

Just like my thoughts.

"I'm fine. Just a little seasick."

A feeble excuse from a Supreme Peak master. Hak Su studied me for a moment before speaking carefully.

“I can’t claim to know everything that troubles you, but if you ever wish to talk, you’re welcome to come to me.”

He laughed heartily, then added, “Of course, I wasn’t being entirely serious, so don’t worry about it. But I can at least tell you some good news that might lighten your heart a little.”

“What good news?”

“By now, word of the situation in Qinghai must have reached the Central Plains. Before long, the Sword Saint—no, the Alliance Leader—will lead the righteous warriors of the world here to join us.”

Hak Su sounded full of hope. For a moment, I’d wondered if he really had good news. Now my spirits sank.

Could that really happen?

First secure your own life, then strike your enemy.

It was an old saying from Go:[3765] make sure you survived before you attacked. And by that measure, the world was still an unstable stockpile of bombs.

Besides…

As long as they have the Moving Formation, it’s almost impossible to commit all our forces to Qinghai alone.

But I swallowed the words on the tip of my tongue. I couldn’t bring myself to crush the hope of the earnest, kind-looking Daoist before me—not while I was still confused myself.

“Hmm.”

“Is something wrong?”

Hak Su looked puzzled by my vague response. I held back a bitter smile and shook my head.

He’d learn the harsh truth soon enough, even if it wasn’t today.

“No. It’s better news than I expected, that’s all. Caught me off guard. Anyway, how much farther to our destination?”

“About half a day, I think.”

“Half a day. Two or three shichen[3766] at most, then.”

Crossing Qinghai Lake directly by ship had saved us a considerable amount of time. I nodded, thinking about what lay ahead, then muttered as I remembered something I’d almost forgotten.

“Oh, right.”

“Is there something you’re curious about?”

“No. It’s about time we hauled him out.”

[3765] Go is an East Asian strategy board game played with black and white stones.

[3766] A shichen is a traditional time unit of about two hours; two or three shichen is about four to six hours.

"Pardon?"

Leaving Hak Su to puzzle over that, I shouted to the house elf who had to be somewhere nearby.

"Head down!"

A moment later, the rude house elf's indignant voice rang out.

"This is driving me crazy! Why now?!"

"Just felt like calling you. Wanted to check where you were."

The house elf—Hyuk Mujin—came running. At my casual answer, he looked like he'd swallowed shit.

"What am I, some stray dog?"

"Absolutely not. What sin did a good dog commit in a past life to deserve being compared to you?"

"…One of these days, I'm going to get sick of this shit and quit."

"Good. Please do."

I laughed quietly at his grumbling and started walking.

"Anyway, how's the job I gave you going?"

"I was right in the middle of it. He's more tight-lipped than I expected."

"And?"

"So I made him heavier. Chained a water jug to his ankle. He loved it."

"Good work. You've got a knack for this."

"What can I say? I learned it all from you, Captain."

As I walked along, chatting with Hyuk Mujin, Hak Su followed behind us, caught up in the situation. He blinked.

"Forgive me, but what in the world are you talking about?"

He stared at the empty deck. I shrugged.

"You'll see."

"But see what—"

"Mujin."

"Yes, sir."

Rrrrattle.

Hyuk Mujin stepped forward briskly and pulled on a chain extending over the side of the deck. A man in black, his whole body blue, rose out of the water.

"Gah! I-I'll talk! I'll talk!"

"On your life?"

"Of course—cough—of course!"

He'd spent a full day and night as one with the blue waters of Qinghai Lake. It was hardly surprising that he might be ready to cooperate now.

Still, I studied the panting man closely.

“If there’s even the slightest lie in what you tell us, your parents will live long, sick lives.”

“…”

“Devoted son, aren’t you? Right, Mujin?”

“Yes, sir!”

“N-No! Anything but that…!”

Rrrrattle. Splash!

Hyuk Mujin answered with gusto and released the chain. The blue water swallowed the man’s desperate scream.

The ancient tradition of dipping someone in the Yangtze lived on at Qinghai Lake.

Chapter 1079

If someone asked me whether a person could survive being dunked in a river hundreds of times over a full day and night, plus another half day, I'd answer without hesitation.

Of course they could.

They might even come out of it far more honest than they'd been before.

Naturally, there might be a few minor complications along the way.

"Ugh… ugh…"

"Captain, this guy's eyes are completely glazed over."

"If they've gone slack, we'll just have to tighten them up."

"How?"

"Slap him across the face. Nice and hard."

"Ah."

Hyuk Mujin nodded as though he'd gained a great insight and promptly raised his palm.

Smack!

"He's not waking up."

"Are you stupid?"

"Why?"

"You have to hit him harder. Until he wakes up."

"Oh. Are you a genius?"

"Not a genius. Just exceptionally gifted."

"Of course."

Mujin gasped in admiration and raised both hands this time.

Smack! Smack! Smack!

"Uh, his eyes rolled back."

"He's exaggerating."

"No, I'm serious. His body's completely ice-cold, too."

"Huh. So it is."

"I told you."

"This bastard's cold because his heart is cold."

"Now isn't the time for nonsense. What if he dies?"

"He won't. I'm here, and my heart's warm."

"What?"

The moment Mujin looked at me as if to say, *What kind of bullshit is this idiot talking about now?* I reached out without hesitation.

Boom!

My palm struck the black-robed man's chest, delivering a burst of Scorching Yang Qi. His body, pale and growing rigid, shuddered. Then warmth flooded back into him—far more than he'd had before.

"…Wow. He actually survived."

"Told you. I have a warm heart."

"Isn't it your internal energy that's warm, not your heart?"

"Want to warm up like him? You look a little cold."

"I must politely decline…"

Crack!

"Gah!"

"What?"

"He bit his tongue! There's so much blood!"

"Oh, for fuck's sake."

"I told you not to release his Mute Acupoint! Even with his internal energy sealed, he could die like this!"

"If I'd sealed his Mute Acupoint, he might've drowned without getting a word out. Anyway, quit making a fuss and go fetch him."

"Fetch who?"

"Who do you think?"

"Oh."

A moment later, a man who'd mastered two utterly different trades—assassination and medicine—revived our emergency patient in the blink of an eye.

"I've stitched him up perfectly. He'll have no trouble speaking once he recovers."

"Thank you."

"But is this the man I'm thinking of?"

"Yes. The one you brought in last time."

"He's so swollen I nearly didn't recognize him. His wrist wound hasn't healed yet, either, so don't overdo it. If it gets infected and the flesh dies, that'll be serious."

"Oh, it's not my body, so that's fine."

"True enough. But keep treating him so roughly and he's liable to die. At a time like this, you'd be better off stabbing deep, three vertebrae below the cervical spine, then slowly…"

"Oh, that's a handy tip. But wouldn't that kill him?"

"He wouldn't die. He'd wish he had."

The expert, second to none in the world when it came to taking apart and treating the human body, passed on his useful tip and left. The black-robed man, who had watched the whole thing unfold right before his eyes, began to thrash.

"Mmph! Mmmph…"

“Hey, why are you acting up again? Hold still.”

“Mmmph!”

“This isn’t working. Mujin.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Hold him down for a bit. I’m trying to practice, but it’s hard when he keeps shaking. I used a Pressure-Point Strike, and he’s still struggling this much. How badly is he thrashing around?”

“This insolent bastard. The Captain’s trying to practice. Heave-ho. Is that good?”

“Yeah. Perfect. All right, I’m going to stab him.”

“Wait. Are you sure that’s the right spot?”

“Isn’t it? I thought he said to start two vertebrae below the cervical spine.”

“Huh? Wasn’t it two above?”

“No way. That’s a lethal acupoint.”

“Now I’m confused. Why don’t you go ask him again, Captain?”

“Why should I go? You go.”

“I could die if I go. He hates having to repeat himself.”

“You think it’d be any different if I went?”

“Fair point. How about stabbing both spots?”

“That’s not a bad idea. Shall we?”

“Yes, sir. Go ahead.”

“Mmmph! Mmmmmmph!”

Rrrrrumble!

The deck shook as if an earthquake had hit—though that might be a slight exaggeration.

The black-robed man thrashed with all his might despite the Pressure-Point Strike. I let out a quiet laugh to myself, then released his Mute Acupoint.

“Gah! Cough, cough!”

“What is it? Got any last words?”

“Th-three vertebrae.”

“Hm?”

“The cervical spine! Three vertebrae *below* it! Stop it, you madmen!”

There were only two reasons to call someone a madman when he could kill you with a flick of his hand.

First, you’d made peace with dying.

Second, you were too terrified to think straight, let alone worry about offending him.

He was clearly the latter.

That’s done.

One look at the terror in his eyes, one listen to his voice, and I knew he'd been reborn a far more honest man. I stood up.

"Huh? You're not going to stab him?"

"Why would I? Get him something to cover himself with, then stay right beside him and have a chat."

"What about you, Captain?"

"I'm about to get busy with something else. Isn't that right?"

At my sudden question, Hak Su swallowed hard. He'd watched the whole scene with the expression of a man who'd seen a ghost.

"I-I'm not sure what you mean."

"Oh, right. You can't see it yet. Over there."

Just as I raised my hand and pointed beyond the bow—

Whoosh.

The thick mist parted, revealing the green land it had hidden.

A group had gathered at the pier to wait for us. Beyond them, faint gray city walls rose in the distance.

Xining, the capital of Qinghai and the last stronghold against Dark Heaven.

So that's Xining.

At that moment—

Ding.

A clear chime rang out above the waters parting before our boat.

The crowd waiting to welcome us was enormous.

No. *Massive* wouldn't have been an exaggeration.

"Waaaaaah!"

"Reinforcements! The Murim Alliance reinforcements are here!"

Was this what those Roman triumphs I'd seen in textbooks had been like?

The cheers swelled as we drew closer to the walls, then shook the whole city the moment we entered. Everywhere I looked, the streets were packed with dark masses of people.

They filled the broad avenues and narrow alleys, as well as the rooftops of countless buildings—including rows of pavilions—and stretched both arms toward us as they cheered.

Even Cheongpung, who usually loved attention, swallowed nervously and whispered, "If this goes on much longer, my ears might burst, Benefactor."

"Yeah?"

"Yes. I'm not joking. I've never heard anything this loud."

"Mirror therapy[3767] works, all right."

"Hm? What's mirror therapy[3768]?"

"It's… never mind. Even if I told you, Cheongpung wouldn't change."

Normally, Cheongpung would have been armed with pure, unbridled curiosity and pressed me to explain what mirror therapy[3769] meant. This time, though, he simply continued in a quiet voice.

"There are so many people. Seriously, so many. I stayed in Xining for a while, but it wasn't anything like this."

Cheongpung had spent about a month in Qinghai before I arrived, so the change must have struck him all the harder.

Of course, I already had a good idea where this enormous crowd had come from.

Everyone scattered across Qinghai must have gathered in Xining.

It was only natural. The same thing had happened earlier in Shanxi, then in Gansu.

The Great Nation's imperial court had already declared Dark Heaven rebels and foreign invaders. A warning like that was essential if the common people, many of whom still thought there was nothing to fear, were going to take the threat seriously.

Unlike the Great Faction War, which had barely affected the common folk, Dark Heaven's actions had long since gone far beyond the bounds of the Murim.

If the Heavenly Demon of the past had set his sights on the Murim, the Lord of Heaven now wanted the whole world.

No—

Maybe even more than that.

I forced down the unease that grew sharper with every passing moment and curled my lips into a smile.

So that the countless people surrounding us, covering every direction, might feel a little more at ease when they saw me smile.

"It's Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung!"

"The Marquis of Shangshan is here!"

"Waaaaah! Long live the Great Nation! Long live His Majesty the Emperor!"

For all their numbers, most of these people knew little about the Murim.

In their eyes, I wasn't just a young martial artist. I was a divine general, carrying out the Son of Heaven's solemn imperial command to punish foreign invaders and save them.

[3767] "Mirror therapy" translates the Korean expression *geoul chiryo*: seeing one's own behavior reflected in someone else and realizing what it is like to be on the receiving end.

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As the cheers swelled, Cheongpung's eyes widened.
"Wow. Everyone seems to like you, Benefactor."
I swallowed a bitter smile and answered quietly.
"Looks that way. For now, at least."
"They'll like you from now on, too. You're such a good person!"
"A good person…"
My voice trailed off as I looked at the crowd filling the city.
Hundreds of thousands, at a glance. Maybe more.
At this very moment, all those people were smiling brightly and cheering for me.
But I had no way of knowing how long those smiles would stay on their faces.
Or, if the worst really did happen, how many of them would survive.
"Cheongpung."
"Yes?"
"Yes?"
"Let's try. As far as we can go."
Still watching the crowd, I added quietly, "Even if it costs us our lives."
Yeah.
Just as we always had.

Chapter 1080

Even as night deepened, the lights of Xining stayed lit.

The countless people still in the streets shared their joy freely, and the city's leaders provided liquor and meat for them.

They hoped the small sparks of hope in those people's hearts would burn a little longer—and a little brighter.

But while laughter still slipped through the gaps around the windows, the mood inside the pavilion was heavy.

"Judging by those long faces, I can guess how things are going."

Jeok Cheongang broke the silence with a click of his tongue.

"Sounds like you've got some shitty news. Spit it out now instead of making a damn fuss later."

"Well…"

Only Jeok Cheongang could say something like that. But with Jeok Cheongang on the receiving end, no one dared be the first to answer.

The leaders trailed off and exchanged glances. That was when I spoke up from beside the window.

"If it's hard to say right now, let's start with the situation inside the city."

The martial world might spell it *Fire Gate Clan* and pronounce it *bunch of bastards*, but of course a young Disciple was easier to approach than an old monster notorious for his foul temper.

At my gentle tone, one of the leaders finally relaxed enough to speak.

"Things aren't looking good."

"Hmm. Not good?"

"That's right."

I pressed my lips together, then asked the speaker, "Understood. And your name?"

"Cheok Mo, Sect Leader of Qinghai's Gonghwa Sect. I don't know if you've heard of us."

Of course I hadn't.

I knew of Gonghwachun,[3770] but I hadn't memorized the dozens of martial sects in Qinghai Province. And his first answer had already made it clear I wasn't likely to remember him, either.

"All right, then. Sect Leader Cheok of the Gonghwa Sect."

"I'm listening."

He nodded lazily. I met his gaze and continued evenly.

"Do you want to be here?"

[3770] Gonghwachun is a Korean Chinese restaurant whose name sounds like Gonghwa Sect.

"…?"

"You're free to leave if you're going to keep stating the obvious."

"…!"

"And since when are we on such familiar terms? What do you think, sir?"

I turned to a middle-aged official dressed in silk robes. He swallowed before answering.

"H-How could I possibly contradict the Marquis of Shangshan?"

"Strange answer. I don't recall asking whether you'd contradict me."

"Y-You are absolutely right!"

"Sure. Anyway, I've been standing for a while, and my legs are getting tired. Is there an open seat?"

I could have stood there for days without a problem, and a slight turn of my head would have shown me plenty of empty chairs. But the official sprang from his seat.

"There's one right here!"

"Oh, you don't have to do that. Especially when you're so much older than me."

"I-I don't know what I should…"

"What do you mean, you don't know? Are you trying to get me cursed out? Make it look like some wet-behind-the-ears kid is throwing his rank around to bully an elder?"

"Th-Then I'll sit."

The official's eyes darted back and forth as he cautiously lowered himself toward the chair. I muttered as if to myself.

"He's actually going to sit. Can't read the room at all."

"…Pardon?"

"Hm? What?"

"What you just said…"

"Oh, did you hear that?"

"…Yes."

"I was only talking to myself. Go ahead and sit."

"…"

"Why do you keep making me repeat myself? Sit down."

A truly clueless man might have eased himself into the chair. This official could only stare at me, his eyes trembling, unable to sit or stand.

Then again, he must have been good at reading the room to have landed such an important post as City Lord at a relatively young age.

That same instinct must've helped him siphon off plenty over the years.

Leaving the City Lord of Qinghai sweating through an imaginary squat, I glanced to my side. Jeong Hogun was smiling with a crooked twist to his lips.

I didn't make a habit of bullying my elders, but what Jeong Hogun had told me on the way to Xining had washed away any guilt I might have felt.

A textbook corrupt official.

The Embroidered Uniform Guard—the imperial family's foremost military force, with intelligence capabilities comparable to the East Depot—had obtained the information long ago. There was no room for doubt.

More important, though, was the state of affairs his negligence had brought about.

"I heard the city's food stores are running low. What do you have to say about that, City Lord?"

"Th-That's…"

"Just the number. No lies."

"W-We had far too many commoners flood the city in a short time…"

"You've got a long tongue. Want me to shorten it?"

"On-One month! One month!"

He blurted out the answer, then added uncertainly, "…Probably."

"That won't do. Thousand Captain Jeong?"

Step.

Jeong Hogun strode forward at my call. The City Lord squeezed his eyes shut and cried out.

"F-Fifteen days! The food we have in storage will last fifteen days at most!"

"Fifteen days. Are you sure this time?"

"I stake my life on it!"

Men with plenty to lose didn't gamble with their lives. That made his answer convincing—and infuriating.

A huge number of refugees had arrived in a short time, but Xining had only been like this for about seven days.

Qinghai was a border province. It was only natural that it would have more military provisions stored away than the Central Plains, in case of an invasion.

And yet there was only enough food for fifteen more days.

He really helped himself.

I sighed and looked at the City Lord. Sweat streamed down his terrified face from his impromptu leg workout.

"Why are you so scared? Anyone would think I was trying to kill you. Wouldn't they?"

"Th-Then…"

"Don't worry. I won't kill you."

"Thank you!"

His face brightened at once. I added gently, "At least not right now."

“I’ll devote my whole heart to serving the Marquis of Shangshan from now on… Pardon?”

“Why ask me to repeat it? You heard me.”

Three or four Embroidered Uniform Guards strode up behind him and surrounded him.

“W-Wait! You can’t do this!”

“Who says I can’t?”

It was a terrible turn of events for the City Lord. But I had saved the imperial family, and the Son of Heaven had personally appointed me a marquis. I had more than enough authority and grounds to do this.

Besides, his fate had been all but decided before I set foot in Xining.

“Send him off at sunrise. And don’t forget to give him some company for the journey. He might get lonely.”

“As you command!”

Jeong Hogun’s answer was firmer than ever. At his gesture, the other Embroidered Uniform Guards waiting nearby swiftly carried out their orders.

“Songak of Qinghai’s Regional Military Commission. Is that you?”

“I-I haven’t done anything wrong!”

“That’s for us to decide. Not you.”

“…!”

“These are the Marquis of Shangshan’s strict orders. Come quietly if you want to see tomorrow’s sunrise.”

It happened in an instant.

Generals in ornate armor and officials in robes as stiff as their necks were dragged out one after another, their faces pale.

Not one of them resisted. No—they didn’t even dare try.

The presence of Supreme Peak masters who could shake the world played a part. But if they opposed the imperial Embroidered Uniform Guard, their entire families could be branded traitors.

Beheaded as corrupt officials in league with the City Lord, or branded traitors and wiped out along with their families. Faced with that choice, they could do only one thing.

Accept reality.

And despair without end.

Unlike the men dragged out wailing as though everything was over, the people would rejoice and draw closer together once this tumor was removed.

And along with that—

“Looks like we’re finally ready to have a proper discussion.”

The dozen or so seats emptied in an instant. Yet the void they left was filled by the presence of the man who had emptied them.

Me.

Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

“What does everyone think?”

“…!”

“…!”

Suffocating silence weighed on the pavilion.

Those close to me smiled without a sound. Those who didn’t know me exchanged dark looks.

Backs that had once been relaxed were now rigidly straight. Fingers tapped the table slowly, anxiously.

Perhaps some of them had dismissed me in private, or tried to diminish what I’d done. Rumors always grew in the telling. And in troubled times like these, people sometimes made heroes because they needed them.

But they were wrong.

There had always been people like that, everywhere. The result had always been the same.

And there had always been people who watched in silence, giving nothing away. Like the young Daoist who looked straight at me now while a few others avoided my gaze.

“Rumors are made from what people see and hear. As usual, I didn’t put much stock in them.”

His Daoist robes were neat, without a single wrinkle, and I couldn’t begin to read the depths of his eyes.

“But now that I’ve met you, fellow Daoist, I see once again that I was right.”

His voice was as calm and composed as his appearance.

“Rumors can’t be trusted. Sometimes the truth falls short of them. Other times… it far surpasses them.”

Rustle.

The young Daoist rose, clasped his hands in greeting, and spoke.

“I am Hak Eui, a First-Generation Disciple of the Kunlun Sect. It is an honor to meet you, Great Hero Jin Taekyung.”

Chapter 1081

“I am Hak Eui, a First-Generation Disciple of the Kunlun Sect. It’s an honor to meet you, Great Hero Jin Taekyung, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.”

Slender build. Refined features.

And a natural manner—not too much, not too little.

He looked somewhere between a young man and a middle-aged one, the very picture of a Daoist. I’d guessed who he was the moment our eyes met, so I bowed in return.

“This is the first time we’ve met like this.”

I couldn’t have said that without knowing who he was. Hak Eui replied calmly, without the slightest change in expression.

“My one and only Junior Brother is rather talkative for a Daoist. So I assumed you’d already heard a thing or two about me.”

I scratched my chin as I looked at Kunlun Cloud Dragon Hak Unui’s eldest Senior Brother, Hak Su’s Junior Brother, and Cheongheoja’s second Disciple.

“Even if he’s not here, that seems a bit harsh on your one and only Junior Brother.”

“It’s all right. I would’ve said the same thing if he were here.”

So that was why people said not to judge by appearances.

Despite his refined looks, Hak Eui had a way of stating the facts coldly. Without hesitation, he continued.

“Earlier, Great Hero Jin, you said we should have a proper discussion. Before that, there’s something I’d like to ask.”

I shrugged in assent, and Hak Eui went on.

“What do you intend to do with the City Lord of Qinghai and his associates who were just taken away?”

The question felt a little out of the blue, but I answered readily.

“Of course I intend to behead them. At daybreak, in front of everyone.”

That outcome had been decided long ago.

The City Lord of Qinghai had managed to survive as a corrupt official for so long because of the conflict between the Son of Heaven and the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord. His illicit fortune had drawn the Embroidered Uniform Guard’s attention a long time ago.

In the end, it was only a question of who would take up the sword. The neck it would sever had already been chosen.

And in a situation like this, it’d be ridiculous to let a man like him live.

Peace had lasted a long time in the Great Nation, too.

The City Lord of Qinghai had spent those years secretly selling off military provisions and lining his pockets with gold. There was no way the army could have functioned properly under a man like him.

There was hardly any answer but beheading.

But Hak Eui's next words went well beyond anything I'd expected.

"No."

"…!"

"…!"

"I ask you to reconsider that decision."

His firm voice sent a stir through the pavilion. Naturally.

If asking what I planned to do with them had been a little out of the blue, this was overstepping.

Even if the Son of Heaven's decree had weakened the principle that officials and martial artists must not interfere with one another, there were still limits.

A line that someone of Hak Eui's standing—the Kunlun Sect Leader's second Disciple—couldn't cross.

And the first person to react when Hak Eui crossed that unseen line was—

"Perhaps you pursued the Dao[3771] and never learned the law. Mind your words, Daoist of the Kunlun Sect."

Jeong Hogun's voice was as blunt as ever, but I noticed a faint anger in his eyes as he looked at Hak Eui.

Some people tensed beneath Jeong Hogun's aura. Cheongheoja, meanwhile, watched his Disciple in silence.

I don't know him well, but he doesn't seem like the sort to sit back and do nothing in a situation like this.

One person makes the mess; another cleans it up.

When a Disciple did something wrong, the Master usually stepped in to handle it.

Even Jeok Cheongang, who ranked among the most hot-tempered men in the world, would sometimes remember to call me out when I acted unreasonably.

Of course, he'd take my side without a second thought first.

But Cheongheoja is different.

Watching Cheongheoja deal with the hopeless trio by the shore of Qinghai Lake had convinced me that the old Daoist was practically a saint.

If a man like him was simply watching the situation unfold, there had to be a good reason.

"Then why?"

"…Marquis of Shangshan."

[3771] Dao means "the Way," the guiding principle in Daoist thought.

Jeong Hogun frowned when I suddenly spoke to Hak Eui, but I ignored him and asked again.

“Tell me. Why should those bastards be kept alive?”

Was this the mercy of a Daoist who followed the Way of Heaven and wanted to avoid taking lives whenever possible? Or was there another reason?

By now, I was genuinely curious.

Everyone’s attention fixed on him. At last, Hak Eui’s tightly closed lips parted.

“I don’t remember saying that.”

“Hm?”

“I only asked you to reconsider beheading them.”

“No, I mean, isn’t that—”

I was about to ask what the difference was when Hak Eui added firmly:

“Beheading is far too lenient. Have them executed by slow slicing in front of the people.”

“…What?”

“At times like this, one punishment should serve as a warning to a hundred. Based on the close investigation I’ve conducted into the city’s affairs over the past few days, even slow slicing seems a little too lenient.”

“…!”

“…!”

Silence fell over the pavilion. Jeok Cheongang, who’d been watching with interest, muttered under his breath.

“What a masterpiece.”

The Slaughter Saint and the Bow Saint, seated beside him, spoke with uneasy expressions.

“Is he… sure he’s a Daoist?”

“How did the Kunlun Sect end up like this…”

As the elders sighed, the hopeless trio tilted their heads at the sight of everyone staring blankly at Hak Eui, then whispered among themselves.

“Wow, I’ve never heard of ‘slow slicing’ before. What does that even mean?”

“Taishan knows.”

Taishan answered confidently, swallowing as he continued.

“I ate it once. It was very tasty.”

No, that couldn’t be right.

“Oh! So it’s a kind of dish. I’ve never tried it. Great Sir, have you?”

“What sort of dish could that possibly be? Honestly, young people these days.”

For once, Great Sir looked at Taishan and Cheongpung with an expression of pure contempt, as if a normal person had possessed him. Then he added:

“‘Slow slicing’ isn’t a dish. It’s a sobriquet. The name of a great fiend who once terrorized the whole world.”

Cheongpung and Taishan gasped at the same time. Their eyes went wide, and they eagerly asked:

“What happened to that great fiend?”

“What do you think? He fell to this lord’s hand.”

No, that couldn’t be right, either.

“Gasp! Then what Taishan ate back then was…”

“This is driving me insane. No, it wasn’t.”

I agreed completely, but why was *that guy* the one saying it?

“Taishan really didn’t know. Who knew a great fiend could be so tasty?”

“How many times do I have to tell you? That’s not what it was.”

He’d said it exactly twice so far—and it hadn’t even been a great fiend.

“No. Taishan really ate it.”

“…Really?”

Don’t let him convince you now. Please.

Are these guys actually insane?

Their intelligence had suffered a thousand cuts, and my head was spinning from listening to them. Just then, an old man’s voice rang out.

“I urged you to follow the Dao[3772], yet it seems this unworthy Master failed to teach his Disciple well enough.”

At last, the Kunlun Sect Leader, Cheongheoja, broke his silence. Hak Eui bowed his head slightly.

“I’m sorry, Master.”

He didn’t look sorry at all.

But whatever he was thinking right now didn’t matter to me. I was only interested in what his unexpected answer had revealed—the fact that had just shocked everyone.

“No, let him continue. Your Disciple still seems to have plenty to say.”

Hak Eui slowly raised his bowed head. A glint passed through his eyes as he looked straight at me.

“What do you mean?”

“You said it yourself. You’ve spent the past few days investigating, and doing so very thoroughly. Wasn’t that what you wanted to talk about from the start?”

“…!”

“Oh, was it not just the past few days? Have you been at it all along?”

[3772]Dao means “the Way,” the guiding principle in Daoist thought.

Across the enormous table, where dozens of people were seated, Hak Eui's eyes widened slightly. I could tell I'd hit the mark, and I laughed quietly to myself.

He and I were both young.

No—we were *very* young compared to the Sect Leaders who held sway over Qinghai's affairs and the Kunlun elders seated here.

But despite that common ground, our positions were worlds apart.

I could claim one of the few seats at the head of the table. He sat at the far end.

All the more reason he needed a chance to speak.

Like this moment, with everyone's attention fixed on him.

"Go ahead. Speak freely. Nobody's going to object, right?"

"Of course not."

Jeok Cheongang answered, adding with a genial smile,

"If anyone has a problem, raise your hand now. This old man will personally persuade you."

Naturally, no one raised a hand. The meeting continued through the night.

When that long night ended, a dozen or so criminals—including the City Lord of Qinghai—were dragged into the streets amid the curses of countless people.

A shrill cry rang out.

A bird streaked across the high sky and arrived as if heralding their end.

No.

A messenger eagle.

Henan, Murim Alliance.

I stared silently at the five characters written on the missive, then drew in a deep breath.

And the next moment—

Rustle.

As soon as I unfolded the missive and read its contents, every hair on my body seemed to stand on end.

"…Damn it."

The curse slipped out as I looked up at the dark sky. Beneath it, the executioners' blades flashed cruelly.

Shhk!

A tremendous roar erupted as a severed head fell.

Chapter 1082

At the same time, Jin Taekyung wasn't the only one watching the public executions from a pavilion overlooking the streets of Xining.

Shhk!

A dozen or so heads rolled from the flashing blades.

Fountains of blood erupted, the headless bodies slumped, and the crowds blanketing the streets roared.

"Waaaaah!"

"Long live His Majesty the Emperor!"

"The Marquis of Shangshan has punished the corrupt officials!"

"You fiends! Rot in hell!"

Some people threw up both hands in celebration. Others, their anger still unsated, kept cursing and jeering.

But the young man looking down at them wore a conflicted expression.

"…Hmm."

A low groan slipped from his lips. Then someone's voice suddenly pierced his ears.

"Oh, there you are."

He spun around in alarm, then sighed in relief when he recognized the unexpected visitor.

"You startled me! When did you get here?"

"When did I get here? We all arrived yesterday. Are you an idiot?"

"Um, Uncle… I wasn't asking when you came to Xining…"

"Then what?"

The shabby, middle-aged man—Great Sir—looked genuinely puzzled. The young man clicked his tongue.

"No, you're right, Uncle Great Sir. We got here yesterday."

"As I suspected. You are an idiot. Kang Pung, you're far too naïve for your age."

"It's Cheongpung."

"That's exactly what I said. Kang Pung."

For a moment, the young man—no, Cheongpung—was at a loss for words. He scratched his chin.

They'd only met a few days ago, and even Cheongpung, whose mind ranged far beyond the limits of ordinary people, sometimes found the man difficult to understand.

For most people, of course, it probably wouldn't be *sometimes*. It would be all the time.

"…I've never met anyone like you."

“The world is vast. You should broaden your horizons like this maiden.”

“Hmm. I’ve been meaning to say this since we first met, but I thought ‘this maiden’ was what women called themselves.”

“So?”

“Huh?”

“Judging people by appearances alone is a grave mistake. What matters is the essence. Only then can you understand the truth hidden within.”

For a moment, Great Sir almost seemed to possess some profound insight. Cheongpung stared at him blankly before he finally spoke.

“You sounded a little like an immortal just then.”

“Did I?”

“Yeah. But at the same time, you seemed a little… unimpressive.”

“Isn’t that a bit harsh? I don’t mind, being this maiden and all, but someone else might be hurt by that.”

“Oh! I’m sorry.”

“No need to apologize. Being stupid isn’t a sin.”

“…Okaaay.”

Cheongpung answered without thinking. He was still wondering whether that had been the right response when the roar outside swelled. Great Sir came over to look out the window.

“How cruel.”

Cheongpung followed his gaze, and his face stiffened.

Some of the crowd were desecrating the bodies of the executed men.

“…It is. I shouldn’t have looked.”

“You seemed down when I saw you from behind a little while ago. Was that why?”

“I never get used to killing. If I were as strong-willed as my Benefactor, I’d be much better off.”

Muttering almost to himself, Cheongpung thought of Jin Taekyung.

No matter what waves of hardship and adversity rose before him, Taekyung always pressed on, never wavering.

People praised the two of them as the Two Dragons, but to Cheongpung, Jin Taekyung was someone to look up to. Not because of strength or talent in martial arts. He admired the way Taekyung lived.

Perhaps that was why Great Sir’s next words left him speechless.

“Did you know? This world calls someone who’s grown used to killing a Killing Ghost.”

“…!”

“The strong-willed ones simply don’t show it. They haven’t gotten used to it. They’re closer to being worn out and utterly exhausted. Someone I knew was like that, too.”

“Do you know someone like that, Uncle?”

“I told you. Broaden your horizons like this maiden.”

Great Sir let out an enormous yawn, then continued.

“But he chose to accept the reality and fate he was dealt. The person you want to be like probably feels the same way.”

“…Uncle Great Sir, is this really who you are?”

“What on earth do you mean, ‘is this who I am’?”

“No, it’s nothing.”

Cheongpung blinked at how easily the words had come from Great Sir’s mouth, then let out a long sigh.

“You’re right. I was so stupid that I spoke without thinking.”

“I’ll say it again: being stupid isn’t a sin. And those men being desecrated even after death aren’t the real sinners, either.”

“They aren’t?”

“Oh, of course they’re sinners. They committed crimes worthy of death, so they deserved to die. But isn’t the real sinner the one who created this hell?”

Great Sir pointed toward the endless sky, gloomy and overcast even at midday.

“I don’t know if the Supreme Deity or whatever is up there, but I’ll bet my balls he’s not all that impressive.”

Cheongpung, who had been listening to Great Sir with a serious expression, tilted his head.

“Um, only men like me have those…”

“I told you, I have them too.”

“No, I mean, *I* have them too.”

“Then that settles it.”

Great Sir continued solemnly.

“You’re clearly a woman like me.”

The Cheongpung of the past might have wondered if that was true. But over the past two years or so, he had acquired at least a little common sense.

“My Second Grandfather said I’m a man.”

“Really? And did your Second Grandfather have them, too?”

“Yeah. I caught a glimpse while he was peeing. He caught me right away, though, and I nearly died.”

“I see.”

Great Sir considered this gravely, then gasped.

“Now I understand.”

“What?”

“He isn’t your grandfather. From now on, call him Second Grandmother.”

“…Be careful. If that gets back to him, he might really kill you.”

“Second Grandmother can’t kill this maiden. Even Slow Slicing,[3773] that vicious great fiend, eventually knelt before me. Though he ended up in Baekdu Gangsan’s belly.”

“Are you talking about Taishan?”

“Well, same difference. How many times must I tell you? What matters is the essence.”

Cheongpung rubbed his temples. For some reason, his head was spinning.

“Whenever I talk to you, I get confused. This has never happened to me before.”

“I understand. Your Intelligence is low.”

“I’ve lost count of how many times you’ve called me stupid. Is that why you came to find me?”

“Of course not. Do I look like I have that much free time?”

Cheongpung answered with more certainty than ever.

“Yes.”

“Not at all. The reason I came to find you was…”

Great Sir had begun confidently, but his voice faltered.

“The, um, reason…”

“Uncle Great Sir.”

“Why do you keep interrupting me? I’m trying to tell you.”

“That was the first time I called you. Be honest—you don’t remember why you came, do you?”

“What nonsense!”

Great Sir snapped, then added hesitantly, “Truthfully, it’s a little hazy. But it can’t have been important, so let’s move on.”

“Are you sure it wasn’t important?”

“I’m sure. I think someone may have asked me to come get you, but if it had been terribly important, I’d remember.”

Just as Great Sir answered firmly, as if to allow no further argument, someone’s presence came rushing toward them from far away.

“Young Hero Cheongpung! Where are you? Damn it, Young Hero Cheongpung!”

A familiar voice. A familiar face.

Cheongpung raised a hand when he spotted Hyuk Mujin hurrying this way and that.

[3773] Slow slicing, or *lingchi*, was a historical form of execution by repeated cuts.

"Oh, Warrior Hyuk!"

"I'm going crazy. Why are you still here? And where'd that Great Sir go?"

"Huh? Uncle Great Sir is right here with me…"

Cheongpung trailed off and blinked.

Great Sir had been standing beside him a moment ago. Now he was crouched close behind Cheongpung, hiding.

"…Uncle?"

"Shh. Pretend you don't know me. Is your Intelligence really that low?"

Cheongpung had no chance to answer.

Before he could even feel exasperated at Great Sir's simple yet flawless concealment technique, Hyuk Mujin hurried over, panting, and said something that struck Cheongpung like a bolt of lightning.

"This is no time to stand around! The Potala Palace in Tibet has joined forces with Dark Heaven!"

"…!"

Cheongpung's eyes widened.

But Hyuk Mujin wasn't finished. What came next was an even greater shock.

"And that's not all! Seafaring King Pa Ryun and Green Forest Battle King Tae Gunak…"

Ever since the conflict with Dark Heaven had begun in earnest, the Murim Alliance had feared the Murim forces of Tibet might join them.

Now Mujin had named the two giants who divided the dark-path Murim between them. Cheongpung knew what word would follow.

Betrayal.

And, as always, his ominous suspicion soon became certainty.

"The smell of manure carried a hundred li.[3774] I knew it had to be you."

The first to break the silence was a massive old man.

His blazing eyes were more intense than the sharp edge of the crescent-bladed guandao in his hand, and the aura pouring from his entire body was as vast as a surging wave.

As vast as his title: the Seafaring King.

"Better than the smell of fish. You've spent your whole life eating it raw. Your belly must be crawling with worms by now. How about you quit your life at sea and come work under this old man?"

[3774] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); a hundred *li* is about 50 km (31 mi).

But the other old man, standing a little over thirty meters[3775] away, was no pushover either.

He was remarkably small, his bones as thin as twigs. Though he looked too old to wring a chicken's neck, he had every right to sneer at Pa Ryun.

If Seafaring King Pa Ryun was the king of the Yangtze, this man ruled the mountains.

The man who had built the Green Forest Alliance of today—the Green Forest Battle King, Tae Gunak.

"'This old man,' my ass. You're a squirt, yet you run your mouth like that. Did you swallow some rotten sewage?"

"Funny, calling me a squirt over a mere one-year age difference. And even if we're only counting our experience in Murim, I'm clearly your Senior."

"Is that why you started calling yourself a king? Because no one would count you among the Ten Kings?"

Pa Ryun fired back as if he'd been waiting for the chance. Tae Gunak's gaze darkened.

"Your tongue's always been the problem."

"Funny. I was about to say the same thing."

The two old men stared at each other in silence. Their auras had taken on visible form, billowing above their shoulders.

As if they might fight to the death at any moment.

But the next instant—

Whoosh.

The two giants of the dark-path Murim swiftly suppressed their auras and quietly clicked their tongues.

Both had spent their lives using any means necessary to get what they wanted. Neither knew when their long rivalry would end, but both knew it wouldn't be today.

"How's the plan?"

"Going smoothly. Just as we were told."

Tae Gunak looked toward the dense forest behind him, his gaze darkening, then added to Pa Ryun:

"Don't forget. Two days. Two days from now."

His voice was deep and low.

"Take control of the Yangtze. That's where it begins."

[3775] A little over 30 m is a little over 98 ft.

Chapter 1083

From the moment good and evil first split apart, things that would never disappear from the world were born.

Bandits were among them.

They stole and plundered, sometimes taking lives in the process. They had been around since time immemorial, and no one had ever managed to root them out.

Where there was light, there would be shadows. As long as people felt desire and emotion, that wheel would keep turning.

Perhaps that was why people had finally accepted this unpleasant fact of life. Rather than spill innocent blood trying to break an unbreakable cycle, they had come to tolerate a measure of coexistence through negotiation.

But now they could sense that the long years of coexistence were coming to an end.

“Hey, have you heard the news?”

Foreboding always ran a step ahead of hope.

In the county towns near the mountains and rivers, people could feel that something was wrong.

“They say a sudden landslide last night completely blocked the road over the mountain. The herb gatherers say it doesn’t look like an ordinary landslide…”

“What do you mean, not an ordinary landslide?”

“I’ve spent all fifty years of my life plowing fields, so I can’t say for sure. But those fellows know what they’re looking at.”

“And?”

“They looked at the ends of the trees swept down with the earth and sand. The trunks hadn’t just bent and snapped. It looked as if someone had taken a few halfhearted swings at them with an axe. And there’d been no real sign of a landslide beforehand.”

“Wait. Does that mean…”

“Who else could it be? Unless ghosts did it, it was those damn bandits.”

“Shh! ‘Those damn bandits’? Watch your mouth. It’s unlikely, but if someone from the Green Forest Alliance hears you…”

“Green Forest Alliance, my ass. What’s wrong with calling bandits bandits? Those highwaymen take two days’ wages just to let you cross a mountain pass!”

“Now, now. I understand how you feel, but the Green Forest Alliance is officially on our side. By imperial decree, they’ve joined forces with the Murim Alliance against the vicious enemies in the west.”

“He’s right. Everyone knows bandits are no good, but they’re not like Dark Heaven, running completely wild. Something similar happened when we were kids, didn’t it?”

“Right. It was the Demonic Cult back then, not Dark Heaven. But I remember the bandits joining forces with the Murim Alliance to fight them. The Green Forest Alliance was formed afterward.”

To these middle-aged men, now well along in years, the Great Faction War was an unforgettable childhood memory.

Ordinary people had suffered little harm, but the news that bloodthirsty murderers who believed in an evil doctrine had invaded the Central Plains had thrown the whole land into turmoil.

So even with these ominous rumors about the Green Forest Alliance, people couldn’t help but remain skeptical. The Green Forest Alliance they remembered was a group formed by bandits who were at least willing to talk. They had long since become a part of everyday life.

But there were other rumors, too.

“Remember those men who passed through our village in the dead of night two days ago?”

“Of course. You mean those strangers? I think they said they were from the Blue Flower Escort Bureau.”

“Right, those men. One of their caravan porters was big as an ox, and he held up that heavy flag without batting an eye. That startled me enough, but then I saw his face. He looked even fiercer than he was big.”

“Why bring them up now? Merchants and escort bureaus pass through here several times a month. There’s nothing unusual about that.”

At the others’ puzzled looks, the middle-aged man who had brought it up lowered his voice.

“They came through, yes. But what matters is where they ended up.”

“What?”

“See for yourself. Herb Gatherer Hong pulled this out of the landslide early this morning.”

The next moment, the middle-aged man pulled a bundled piece of cloth from his robe and unfolded it. Everyone who saw it widened their eyes.

More precisely, they stared at the two characters revealed as the dried mud and grains of sand fell away.

Blue Flower.

“T-This is…”

“If you remember that big porter, you’ll remember the flag he was carrying. That’s right. This is the escort bureau’s flag.”

They looked at one another and swallowed hard.

A flag meant something to any group. Soldiers would give their lives to protect their commander's banner, and the merchants and escort bureaus these people knew took pride in their flags, too.

So what did it mean that the flag of an escort bureau that had taken the mountain road just two nights ago had turned up buried in a landslide? That a suspicious landslide had blocked the only way through barely a day later?

"You can guess what this means, can't you?"

"…You don't think?"

"It's not a question of what I think. The Green Forest Alliance—those damned bandits—must have done something. For some reason, they killed to silence the witnesses, then tried to hide it with a staged landslide."

A suffocating silence settled over them.

Their fears were taking shape, and every detail seemed to fit. The thought left them struggling to breathe.

"B-But what would they have to gain? They fought the Demonic Cult in the past. As a reward, they got to call themselves an alliance, like the river pirates on the Yangtze, and live well enough."

"Remember what you said at the harvest two years ago?"

"Two years ago? What does that have to do with anything?"

"You were disappointed. It was the best harvest in nearly ten years, but you sighed and said it still wasn't enough. Why would those men be any different?"

"…!"

"It's obvious. Even we farmers get greedy. What about men who make their living taking what belongs to others?"

Their circumstances were different, but the comparison held.

The middle-aged tenant farmer was speaking only from his own experience and his low opinion of bandits. Still, there was reason enough behind what he said.

The Demonic Cult had wanted only the Central Plains Murim. Dark Heaven wanted the world itself.

Anyone who won this gamble could become a true king of a nation, instead of merely being called one of the Ten Kings.

A new world.

Under a new ruler.

And among the news that had reached this little village was a story far more shocking than the still-unconfirmed rumors of the Green Forest Alliance's betrayal.

"Even the Murong Family of the orthodox faction—the one supposedly full of Great Heroes of Benevolence and Righteousness—joined forces with those vicious enemies. Why wouldn't a bunch of thieves?"

At the mention of the Murong Family, one of the Five Great Families, which had unleashed a bloodbath across the northern lands, the others shut their mouths as if on cue.

Of course. Those men were bandits by nature. Taking from others was their way of life. Why would betrayal trouble them?

If they won this enormous gamble—if they survived to the end—they could gain wealth and glory beyond anything they had known before.

“What an age of chaos.”

The old man sitting in the corner had quietly voiced what they were all thinking. His next words came out like a sigh and fed their mounting unease.

“With the mountains in such an uproar, the river won’t stay calm.”

Soon, his words came true.

Two days after the two giants of the dark-path Murim faced one another.

If you asked whose the vast, boundless Yangtze was, those in the Murim would answer without hesitation.

Not the Five Great Families or the Nine Sects and One Gang. The Yangtze River Channel League.

But those outside Murim would give a different answer. Mountain or river, everything beneath the lofty sky had only one master.

The Son of Heaven.

Seafaring King Pa Ryun had never liked that one bit.

“When this old man was a child, an old man who lived next door told me the Son of Heaven had dragon blood in his veins. A child of Heaven, he said, who must be served with all one’s heart and soul.”

His voice was low but carried force, and his profound internal energy made the space around him tremble.

“He had a bad temper, but he was a decent enough old man. When I was orphaned by one bad harvest after another, he took me in for a while.”

Pa Ryun’s gaze grew distant as he looked back on his past.

He had gone over those memories hundreds, thousands of times. Almost none were good. He had lost both parents before he was old enough to grow a beard, and being taken in by that old man—working hard as a servant just to get enough to eat—had been among the better times.

Even that hadn’t lasted.

“It was a damnable age. More than ten fools called themselves kings, and so-called imperial troops could march into a village in broad daylight, loot it, and kill its people without anyone holding them to account.”

Pa Ryun stroked his sparse beard.

It was a familiar story. The old man had died then.

Not at the hands of a defeated army or bandits, but the imperial troops marching forward with sharp spears and tall banners.

The twelve-year-old boy, grateful to the old man, killed the soldier who had driven a spear into the old man's frail body, then ran.

"I ran for three days and nights without stopping. I finally shook off my pursuers, reached the riverbank, and collapsed. And a thought came to me."

Pa Ryun pointed at the sky.

"There were so many people claiming the world belonged to them. If the so-called children of Heaven were like that, who was I supposed to serve?"

The long age of chaos eventually ended.

A hero surnamed Zhu unified the continent and proclaimed to all under Heaven that he alone was the Son of Heaven.

By then, the boy had become a young man, and the servant had become a river pirate. Watching the new Son of Heaven ascend the throne, Pa Ryun found his answer.

"That was when I learned that anything could be won with spears and swords. Only the final victor could prove his claim through the outcome."

But Pa Ryun knew his own limits better than anyone. He had neither a cause that would let him claim the world nor the strength to take it.

He could, however, take this vast river.

And with it came hundreds of ships and thousands of men—enough to face the Great Nation's warships now appearing in the distance.

"Raise the sails. The time has come."

Fwoosh.

A great expanse of cloth billowed above Pa Ryun's broad smile.

As countless ships followed the flag, the black-clad man at his side quietly curled his lips into a smile.

Chapter 1084

The endless waves of the Yangtze roll on.

The line came from a poet of long ago, celebrated in his day as the Poet Sage.[3776]

He had revered the distant history held in the Yangtze's waters, and the beauty of the river itself. The man sitting at the bow with his eyes closed felt the same.

No. Naturally, he felt it even more deeply.

He had loved the Yangtze since childhood, become a river pirate, and in time made Ship-Fire Boy a name that symbolized him.

Boom. Boom. Booooom!

Drumbeats spread across the water like ripples, and the man opened his eyes. He was Mu Song, the Seafaring King's second Disciple and Stronghold Lord of Water Dragon Stronghold.

"Stronghold Lord. The order has finally come."

Mu Song nodded gravely. Even without his subordinate's report, he knew better than anyone where the drumbeats had come from.

The Sea Dragon Ship.

The vessel of his Master, Seafaring King Pa Ryun.

In the final battle against the Yellow River Channel League, once their only rival, it had sunk dozens of ships single-handedly. It was the mightiest vessel on the river.

Now the Sea Dragon Ship, which no one dared challenge, was cutting through the current with the Yangtze's greatest martial artist aboard and its sails fully spread.

It was headed toward the Great Nation's military vessels—the ships of the Yangtze's other master.

No—the Yangtze's master in all but name.

But today will be different.

Today, we'll show them that we—the Yangtze River Channel League—are the Yangtze's true rulers.

Mu Song muttered the words to himself and thrust his fist into the air. His subordinates roared, and the wind filled the sails.

Whoooosh!

The bow cut through the water.

Just as they charged toward the Great Nation's vessels like horses across an open plain, something dark and grayish emerged between the vessels that had turned obliquely to face them.

"Fire!"

At that instant—

[3776] The Poet Sage is Du Fu, a Tang-dynasty poet. The opening line quotes his poem "Ascending the Height."

Boom! Boom!

More than a hundred Hongyi cannons[3777] roared at once.

Weapons the Great Nation's navy could possess, but no mere band of river pirates could.

Lumps of iron capable of crushing a human body in an instant came hurtling through the air from two hundred *zhang*[3778] away. Even at that terrifying sight, Mu Song's eyes didn't waver.

He was no mere river pirate.

Whoosh.

His form blurred. He kicked off the bow and shot forward, the great saber in his hand tracing a vicious arc toward an incoming cannonball.

Kaboom!

The recoil from deflecting it sent Mu Song back onto the bow. His hand tingled around the hilt, and he shouted, "Charge! Charge!"

"Waaaah!"

Answering with a mighty roar, the swift ships the Yangtze River Channel League was so proud of surged forward even faster.

Every river pirate gathered here was a handpicked elite. Trained in martial arts, the oarsmen rowed with strength and speed, while the Peak masters stationed at the vanguard did everything they could to shield the ships from the hail of cannonballs.

Even they had limits.

Rumble!

"Arrrgh!"

"The ship—the ship's sinking!"

A tremendous boom swallowed the screams. Shattered swift ships began to sink all around them.

Hundreds of ships gathered together made one enormous target.

The League's ships were built for speed rather than durability. Their hulls were small and sleek—which meant a single cannonball could easily send one to the bottom.

Boom! Boom!

Even so, Mu Song narrowed his eyes as cannonballs missed the hulls by a wide margin and slammed into the water.

As I thought. They haven't set up a proper barrage.

[3777] Hongyi cannons were large, European-style cannons adopted by China.

[3778] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 meters, or 9.94 ft. Two hundred *zhang* is about 606 meters, or 1,990 ft.

The latest cannonballs hadn't arrived together on a signal. In fact, nothing had been coordinated since the first volley.

Despite the constant, deafening blasts, the League's losses were minor compared with its full strength. He could even see military vessels sinking because their own cannons had misfired.

The enemy fired at staggered intervals, without waiting for orders from the flagship. They looked as though something were chasing them, shooting the moment each cannon was ready.

The river pirates had been tense, knowing full well what cannons could do. Now smiles were beginning to spread among them.

"Stronghold Lord, they look flustered."

"Shit. I nearly pissed myself, and now I just feel embarrassed."

Mu Song nodded at his subordinates' relieved remarks. "Just as my Master said."

"Pardon? The Chief Stronghold Lord—no, the Alliance Leader?"

"That's right. He said they'd be caught unprepared after so many years of peace."

Mu Song thought the same as his Master.

A predator grew lazy once the hunt was over.

For a long time, no one had risen to challenge the Great Nation, which ruled the vast continent alone. The Yangtze River Channel League was only an alliance of river pirates, tolerated to a certain extent. Peace, when it lasted too long, had a way of making people weak.

Of course, the Great Nation had an elite fleet that kept up its training in case of emergency. But that fleet was on the sea, not the river.

Ever since the Great Nation unified the continent, the only enemies it had needed to watch for were foreign ones.

We'll win this battle.

Just as Mu Song quietly repeated the words to himself, sure of victory, one of the chuckling subordinates suddenly spoke up.

"Still, there's something that feels a little off."

"What do you mean?"

"It's not that I'm complaining, exactly, but…"

The subordinate scratched the back of his head, then added hesitantly, "Are we really supposed to be doing this?"

"What?"

"It just doesn't feel right. We've managed well enough up to now, so why stab the Murim Alliance in the back and join hands with those rotten bastards in Dark Heaven…?"

He trailed off, looking uneasy. The others exchanged glances and began to chime in.

"Well, Dark Heaven does stink to high heaven. Those orthodox faction bastards may talk shit about us behind our backs, but they're not that rotten."

"Yeah, yeah."

"Orders are orders. Underlings like us have to follow them. But it doesn't sit right."

The subordinates had been murmuring among themselves, but when they saw their leader's expression stiffen, they fell silent. The truth was, Mu Song wasn't at ease either.

Are we really supposed to be doing this?

The more he thought about what the man had said, the more bitter his mouth felt.

Perhaps it tasted all the more bitter because, deep down, he knew better than anyone why they were doing it.

Even if it's my Master's order... I can't bring myself to like this.

Mu Song had never once thought of himself as a *junzi*.[3779]

A river pirate.

Just as the name said, he was a thief. He couldn't deny that.

But he had never crossed a certain line.

He never took from anyone who looked poor, and if one of his subordinates committed murder, Mu Song punished him severely on the spot.

But this. This is...

Mu Song looked out over the river, filled with thunder and chaos, and swallowed the words rising in his throat.

At the same time, a face suddenly came to mind.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

He'd borrowed their swift ships so many times it was practically theft, then bossed them around like servants. He was a thief worse than they were, if anything. But Jin Taekyung was still a chivalrous hero.

So was the fearsome Fire King. Even the Slaughter Saint.

They had fought Dark Heaven, which had plunged the world into misery, and stood against injustice.

Come to think of it, did helping them make me a chivalrous hero for a little while too?

At the absurd thought that flashed through his mind, Mu Song bit his lip without realizing it.

And pointless.

Now that they had come this far, he couldn't undo anything on his own.

[3779] A *junzi* is the Confucian ideal of a morally upright person.

He and his Junior Brother, the Iron-Water Divine Dragon, had already voted against this. But the First Disciple and several key Elders had persuaded their Master, and his resolve had held firm.

At last, the time has come. This is our one chance to become the Yangtze's true rulers.

That had settled everything.

It was an order from his Master and Alliance Leader, Seafaring King Pa Ryun—a man as exalted as the heavens in Mu Song's eyes.

For a Disciple who trusted and followed his Master as though he were a god, there could be no more objections or stray doubts. There must not be.

He was a river pirate, and he would remain one.

"…We'll finish this quickly. Everyone, get ready."

Leaving his subordinates to watch him anxiously, Mu Song gripped the great saber in his hand with all his might.

The Yangtze, shrouded in thick cannon smoke rising even now, looked strange and unsettling, as if he were seeing it for the first time.

Damn it.

Swallowing the curse on the tip of his tongue, Mu Song recalled a line from an old poet's verse. He had recited it until he was hoarse, despite never even finishing the Thousand Character Classic.[3780]

Why were the waters of the Yangtze, which should have flowed so steadily as always, churning so violently and red?

His brief reverie ended as the shadow of a military vessel drew close.

Rumble—crash!

A tremendous impact.

The moment the swift ship's sharp ram slammed into the side of the military vessel—

Whoosh!

Mu Song kicked off the bow and leaped up, bringing his great saber down with all his strength toward a group of government troops preparing to fight on deck.

At the same time, he saw them clearly.

The fear and tension in their eyes. Their trembling spears and blades. Their bodies frozen in place.

"…Damn it."

The curse escaped him at last. At the final moment, Mu Song twisted his saber with all his strength.

The blade energy gathered along it vanished like smoke, and the keen edge turned aside.

[3780] The *Thousand Character Classic* is a classical Chinese text used to teach reading and writing.

Thud! Thump!

The soldiers crumpled limply with dull blows instead of sharp cuts.

“Huh?”

His subordinates climbed onto the deck behind him and stared, eyes wide. Before any of them could speak, Mu Song said quietly, “Don’t kill them. We’ll need men to row.”

The river pirates looked at one another blankly, then grinned.

“You all hear that? The Stronghold Lord says to leave them alive.”

“Of course. Who’d dare disobey an order like that?”

They all knew how flimsy the excuse was.

But this was not the Yangtze they wanted to see.

Rumble! Boom!

Military vessels sank one after another in flames. Cries of agony rang out from every direction. Watching and listening, Mu Song silently addressed his Master aboard the Sea Dragon Ship far away, sinking everything that stood in its path.

Is this what the Yangtze you wanted so badly is supposed to look like?

That day, in just two *shichen*[3781], the Yangtze River Channel League sent around a hundred military vessels carrying thousands of government troops to the bottom of the river. Then its ships turned west.

Somewhere far to the west.

And the astonishing news was enough to turn the world upside down.

[3781] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of about two hours; two *shichen* are about four hours.

Chapter 1085

The rumors spread in an instant.

From mouth to mouth.

On the beating wings of messenger pigeons.

Along with the hooves of horses racing across mountains and fields under the crack of whips, and the smoke of beacon fires staining the sky gray.

Before the people shaken by the astonishing news could even determine whether it was true, they saw it with their own eyes.

Countless ships cutting swiftly through the river, their flags billowing proudly in the favorable wind.

The Yangtze River Channel League.

The moment they made out the five characters on those wind-swollen flags, they knew that denying it any longer would mean hiding from reality.

Everything they had seen and heard was no baseless rumor.

It was true.

A mere band of river pirates, who had lived off the Yangtze with the world's tacit consent, had at last become its true rulers.

And they had done it against the Great Nation itself—the master of the world.

"…Gods of heaven and earth."

The groan that slipped from someone's lips sounded hollow.

The vast empire founded under the Mandate of Heaven[3782] was collapsing.

No—their heaven was.

"If this isn't defying heaven, then what is?"

More than a hundred years had passed since the age of warring heroes ended and a unified dynasty was born.

The country folk, who had revered the Great Nation ruled by the Son of Heaven as heaven itself, trembled with unease. Confucian scholars groaned as they realized that the order they had taken for granted had crumbled. Betrayed martial artists seethed with anger and shock.

"Those bandits finally…!"

"I knew something was off. We should never have trusted dark-path figures in the first place!"

But the Yangtze River Channel League's betrayal wasn't the only news to shock everyone.

"Two days ago, the Green Forest bandits rebelled in Hubei and Shaanxi!"

[3782] The Mandate of Heaven is a traditional Chinese doctrine that a ruler's authority depends on heaven's approval, which can be lost through misrule.

The Green Forest Alliance, which divided the world's dark-path forces with the Yangtze River Channel League, had risen up.

And people belatedly realized that storm clouds were gathering beyond the distant Great Wall as well.

"An urgent report from Sichuan! Potala Palace in Tibet is on the move!"

Potala Palace.

The news that the esoteric monks—counted among the Three Outer Powers alongside the North Sea Ice Palace and Nanman Beast Palace—had finally broken their long silence and stirred to action surprised no one in the Murim.

In their eyes, as people of the Central Plains, Potala Palace had been nothing more than a pseudo-religion following evil doctrines since the distant past.

The New Murim Alliance had sent envoys to seek an alliance several times since its founding, but Potala Palace had always answered with silence. For them to act now, in a situation like this, could only mean one thing.

"…Dark Heaven. It's them again."

Fortunately, Sichuan had powerful reinforcements.

Unlike the North Sea Ice Palace, which remained neutral as always, Nanman Beast Palace had overcome the threat of civil war thanks to the astonishing exploits of a young man and resolved to ally itself with the Murim Alliance.

So attention turned to the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance.

The initial shock soon passed, and quite a few people began to scoff at the dark-path forces' uprising.

"Even if they've won a great victory, dark-path figures are still dark-path figures. Nothing's changed."

It wasn't entirely wrong.

The Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance together had nearly twenty thousand men, but if numbers alone were enough to take everything, the Murim world would belong to the Beggars' Sect.

Everyone was confident that the orthodox factions, now completely united around the Murim Alliance, wouldn't be shaken by a force this small.

"Shaanxi has Huashan and Zhongnan, and Hubei has Wudang and the Zhuge Clan. If the Son of Heaven's Imperial Army moves out too, those bastards will regret joining hands with Dark Heaven."

But that prediction had several fatal flaws.

First, the Zhongnan Sect had very few forces left at its headquarters.

Second, most of the hundreds of thousands of Imperial Army troops were concentrated in Jiangsu, where the Imperial Capital and the Son of Heaven were located.

Third, the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League were advancing west in broad daylight, making no effort to hide, and their forces were far larger than anyone had expected.

Like a snowball growing as it rolled down a snowy slope.

“The Green Forest bandits gathered in Hubei crossed Tongsan half a *shichen*[3783] ago! Their numbers are estimated at around five thousand!”

“Five thousand? What in the—”

“Weren’t there only around three thousand half a day ago?”

“W-Well, it seems the forces scattered among the various strongholds have joined them.”

“That’s absurd!”

But the men who so fiercely rejected the messenger’s report soon learned that another force had joined the two groups of outlaws secretly gathering around Hubei and Shaanxi since before the great battle in Gansu.

And it had reached them by the very means the Central Plains Murim feared most.

“…Damn it. They must have used that accursed dark art.”

“Dark art? You don’t mean…”

“I do. A Moving Formation.”

The existence of the Moving Formation had once been guarded with the strictest secrecy. Now it was no longer known to only a tiny handful of people.

As long as people had eyes and ears, secrets would eventually get out.

The Murim Alliance leadership and the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, led by the Thousand-Faced Fox Song Ho, had stepped forward, but for some reason, the secret of the Moving Formation had still gotten out. Now that the Sect Leaders and Family Heads had confirmed it was real, a chill ran through them.

We have to strike. Right now.

The Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance were, after all, coalitions of separate groups.

Their Stronghold Lords commanded anywhere from a few dozen to several hundred, or even a thousand, men each. They pledged loyalty to their respective alliance leaders and repeatedly gathered and dispersed at their command.

Now was the best time to strike.

Before the enemy had fully assembled. Before they could gather in one place and become a powerful force.

But the complication everyone had secretly feared had come to pass.

No one even knew where the Moving Formations were, and Dark Heaven’s powerful forces were using them to join the dark-path figures.

[3783] A *shichen* is a traditional unit of time lasting approximately two hours; half a *shichen* is about one hour.

What if we fight them now?

It was dangerous.

The Moving Formations alone posed an enormous threat, and there was no guarantee of victory.

Shaolin, the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim, had suffered terrible losses. So had the Sichuan Tang Clan, which held its place among the Five Great Families with deadly poisons and hidden weapons. Even Nanman Beast Palace and the Hebei Peng Family had been badly hit.

That wasn't all. According to reports, the Kongtong and Zhongnan Sects had also been hit hard in Gansu.

The damage was no less severe than during the Great Faction War, a time no one wanted to remember. If anything, it was worse.

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families.

With even the fifteen great trees supporting the Murim world trembling at their roots in the typhoon stirred up by Dark Heaven's storm clouds, it was no easy thing to summon the courage to risk everything and face the danger.

Least of all Sect Leaders and Family Heads, who were responsible for their dependents' lives as well as their own.

"I… I give up."

"Sir Seok! What are you saying?"

"Let's be realistic. Do you think the forces gathered here can stand against them?"

"But—"

"You know it too, don't you? The outcome is already decided. We have to conserve what strength we can. Fortunately, those traitors who joined hands with Dark Heaven are heading only west. We can avoid a clash for now."

"Fortunately? Did you just say 'fortunately'? Do you really not know what they're after?"

"I know. They want to pin down the reinforcements from the Central Plains and take Qinghai completely into their grasp. That must be their goal."

"And you know that, yet…!"

"But this time, I have no choice. I'm no Supreme Peak master, nor am I a Sect Leader of one of the Nine Sects and One Gang. I'm sorry."

"Sir Seok!"

"Please don't call me that. I'm not worthy of it. I'm just a cowardly Sect Leader who wants to keep his dependents safe."

He muttered the words bitterly and left. Several other Sect Leaders, their faces downcast, got up and followed him.

Then the refined-looking middle-aged man who had been watching quietly from the seat of honor rose too.

Scrape.

The others had watched the departing Sect Leaders with anger and a sense of betrayal, though part of them understood. Now their eyes widened.

They had been certain that even if everyone else left, this man wouldn't.

"F-Family Head!"

"What is this?"

But contrary to their fears, the middle-aged man merely shrugged, his expression calm.

"Ah, don't misunderstand. I'm just going to get some air."

The others relaxed, then sighed.

A third of Hubei Murim's leading figures had just left, and he was going to get some air?

It was just like him. That didn't make it any less ridiculous.

"Why now, of all times?"

"Yes. Right now."

"There's so much to discuss. Even the Murim Alliance hasn't made a proper decision yet…"

"If it's that urgent, I'll just piss right here."

"Pardon?"

As the others stared at him in bewilderment, the middle-aged man clutched the front of his trousers, looking grave.

"My bladder's about to burst."

"…!"

"I don't know whether it's age or all this time I've spent away from our family, living out in the world, but my bladder seems to have gotten weak. And even when I'm sitting still, a certain private spot on my backside starts tingling…"

He rambled on until he noticed their expressions, then smacked his lips.

"Well, I shouldn't have brought it up. Let's get back to our discussion."

"…Just go."

"No, no. I'll wet myself right here. I'm sure even Zhuge Wuhou did when he was busy."

"Please go. We're begging you."

"Oh? Then it's all right if I do?"

"Yes. For our sake, please."

"You've begged me so earnestly three times. I suppose I'll have to follow the story of the Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage.[3784]"

[3784]The Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage alludes to Liu Bei visiting Zhuge Liang three times to persuade him to serve as his adviser.

The middle-aged man smiled at the half-resigned group—Zhuge Feng, Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, or rather, the Crouching Dragon Guest—and hurried out.

He didn't head for the privy. Instead, he wound through maze-like paths for some time before reaching the garden in the Inner Hall, where only the Family Head was permitted to enter. There he finally stopped.

"It's all well and good to stay out of sight, but you should at least tell me where to find you."

In a corner of the spacious garden, someone stood with their back to him, gazing at a mulberry grove said to have been planted by Zhuge Kongming himself.

Zhuge Feng added quietly, "Don't you agree, Alliance Leader?"

Chapter 1086

To put it kindly, he had an open, easygoing face. Put it less kindly, he was the sort of young man you might forget soon after meeting him.

He was neither tall nor short, with a natural air that let him blend in wherever he went.

Perhaps that was why no one had thought of the title Sword Saint when they saw the young man beside Zhuge Feng, who had returned to his family after a lengthy absence.

“Oh, there you are.”

Mae Jonghak finally turned around and smiled at Zhuge Feng.

His eyes were deep yet clear, and his smile seemed to put anyone who saw it at ease.

While the world was gripped by turmoil and anxiety, the Murim Alliance Leader—who ought to have borne a heavier burden than anyone else—continued in an almost childlike tone.

“I wandered around for a while and got bored. Then I started walking wherever I felt drawn, and somehow I ended up here.”

“You came here without knowing where you were?”

“I did.”

“This garden and everything within roughly a hundred *jang*[3785] of it are part of the Family Head’s Hall. Even our family’s direct descendants need my permission to enter.”

“Is that so? I did think something was a little odd. I could sense people hiding here and there, and there were all sorts of mechanisms and formations, along with quite a few arrays.”

Zhuge Feng could only let out a hollow laugh.

“Is something good happening?”

“Not at all. I just find this funny.”

The Zhuge Clan was a place even the greatest thieves in the world wouldn’t dare try to break into.

The Heaven-Stealing Thief, who was said to be capable of stealing from heaven itself, had once had the nerve to enter the Zhuge Clan’s Family Head’s Hall. He promptly got caught in its mechanisms and formations and wandered for over a month.

At the time, he was the greatest thief in the world. In the end, the Zhuge Clan’s martial artists rescued him on the merciful order of the previous Family Head. Released with nothing but skin and bones left, he had this to say:

[3785] A *jang* is ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A hundred *jang* is about 303 m (994 ft).

> “Break into the imperial palace, and you’ll be tortured to death. Break into the Sichuan Tang Clan, and you’ll be poisoned to death. But break into the Zhuge Clan, and they’ll rob you down to your soul and let you starve to death.”

And so the Three Forbidden Places were born, leaving a painful lesson for the thieves who came after him.

Of course, it had now been proven that even the Zhuge Clan’s Family Head’s Hall—where the greatest thief of the age had nearly starved to death—was powerless before the greatest swordsman in the world.

“My apologies. If I’d known this was the Family Head’s Hall, I would’ve asked permission.”

“I was in a meeting at the time.”

“Does the door stay shut if the homeowner isn’t there? I could’ve asked the people hiding around here to let me in.”

“Even if you had asked, would they really have opened it and said, ‘Goodness, where have you been all this time?’”

“True enough. It’s not as if I could tell them I’m the Alliance Leader.”

As Mae Jonghak scratched the back of his head, Zhuge Feng shook his own.

People called Zhuge Feng a bit of an eccentric, but compared to the man before him, he couldn’t hold a candle to him.

“So, what were you doing here?”

“Taking in the scent.”

“The scent?”

Zhuge Feng cocked his head.

Though he had been the Family Head for many years, he had visited this garden only a handful of times.

Part of the reason was that he spent most of his time studying and researching mechanisms and formations. But the place was also far too rugged to call a flower garden.

“As you can see, this garden is full of nothing but mulberry trees. There isn’t much to look at, and they don’t smell especially nice.”

“That’s not so. Everything in the world has its own scent. These mulberry trees are no different.”

Mae Jonghak added quietly, “Nor are the plum blossoms that must be blooming somewhere beyond my reach right now.”

Something in his faint voice made Zhuge Feng fall silent for a moment. Then he asked carefully, “Do you… want to return to Huashan?”

“I always have. But not at a time like this. I know where I need to be.”

"Then…"

"I just miss those peaceful days. That day I lay in the sunlight, in a forest thick with plum blossoms."

Mae Jonghak reached out and stroked a nearby mulberry tree.

Perhaps because of the unseasonable cold, its branches drooped without a single fruit. It looked much like the world did now.

"One day, this mulberry tree will bear fruit too. Don't you think?"

"It will. No—I'll make sure it does. With my own hands."

Mae Jonghak gave a faint smile at Zhuge Feng's firm reply.

"Your hands are precious. Put them to work elsewhere. Rough work like this calls for a swordsman like me."

"…!"

Zhuge Feng's eyes trembled as he understood what Mae Jonghak meant.

A year.

Short, if you called it short. Long, if you called it long.

Now, at last, the results of the work they had pursued more fiercely than anything before were drawing close. He could feel it in his skin.

Even Zhuge Feng, who already knew every step and turn of the plan, was shaken.

"Alliance Leader, do you mean…"

"We can't keep taking hits forever. So many people have endured and waited for so long."

"Then, at last?"

Mae Jonghak nodded quietly.

"We can't let this chance pass us by. We may never get another."

"…!"

"You've worked hard, Family Head Zhuge. Without your efforts, we wouldn't have this opportunity today."

Zhuge Feng managed to steady himself. He took a deep breath, then replied,
"No. It's thanks to everyone's sacrifices, great and small."

He looked down at his hand, still trembling.

It was rough and coarse.

Like the hand of a martial artist who had spent their whole life training.

Gone were the slender, delicate hands of a man who had learned only the minimum martial arts required of a Family Head, hands whose calluses had slowly faded away.

Ever since the dark cloud of Dark Heaven had spread across the world, he had waited for this day.

The day he could prove why he had spent so long away from home.

“Have you decided who will stay and who will leave?”

“Yes.”

“You know what your mission is.”

“How could I not? I’ve been waiting for this moment all along.”

“The preparations are complete. Everyone under heaven is ready.”

Mae Jonghak stressed the final words, then pulled a rolled-up sheet of paper from his robes and held it out.

“This is…”

“Chief Song gave it to me before I left Henan.”

Mae Jonghak’s absence was currently being kept an absolute secret. At the mention of Song Ho, Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, Zhuge Feng’s gaze grew intent.

“What’s on it?”

“The names of the spies still in our ranks, along with the people who’ll join you and a rough map marking where you’re to meet them.”

As Zhuge Feng unrolled the letter and read it for himself, delight flashed in his eyes.

“Just as I thought…”

“It took the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, the Beggars’ Sect, and the Lower District Sect working together. Chief Song personally selected everyone involved, so there’s no need to worry about the secret getting out.”

“I thought as much. I’ll carry it out without the slightest mistake.”

“Everyone’s worked hard to cultivate this field. We can’t let birds or insects peck away at it.”

“Don’t worry. Getting here was painful and hard, but I’ll finish the harvest in one swift stroke, without a single mistake.”

“I trust you.”

Mae Jonghak took the letter back from Zhuge Feng and channeled internal energy into his hand.

Whoosh.

Flames of Samadhi True Fire engulfed the paper, and ash scattered on the wind.

Mae Jonghak had burned the letter against any chance of it being found. Watching him, Zhuge Feng clasped his hands together with utmost respect.

He already knew it was time for the greatest swordsman in the world to leave.

“Travel safely, Alliance Leader.”

Zhuge Feng bowed with sincere respect.

When he raised his head again, all that remained were hundreds of mulberry trees trembling in the cold wind.

“What a hurry. He left without even saying goodbye.”

Zhuge Feng gave a quiet chuckle and reached out to touch a drooping mulberry branch.

These trees were said to have been planted by the Zhuge Clan's ancient ancestor, Zhuge Wuhou, and were one of the clan's symbols. But the story the common folk liked to repeat was nothing more than a rumor.

Wuhou followed Emperor Zhaolie of Han[3786] to settle in Bashu.[3787] There's no way the mulberry trees he planted himself could be thousands of li[3788] away, in Hubei.

These mulberry trees had been planted by Zhuge Wuhou's descendants, who laid the foundation for the Zhuge Clan as it stood today.

They had planted them to carry on the Zhuge family line—and to remember their great ancestor.

No one knew what had become of the hundreds of mulberry trees that must have remained in Shu Han, which had ultimately fallen after Zhuge Wuhou's death.

But their roots lived on in a new land.

As long as a single seed remained, the line would not end.

"What matters is the people, not the land."

Murmuring softly, Zhuge Feng brushed the frost from the branch.

"When I come back, I hope you'll be bearing fruit."

With one last faint smile, Zhuge Feng turned and walked away without hesitation.

A few moments later, he came upon the people tearing through the Inner Hall, worried their Family Head might have been assassinated in the privy. Without warning, he said, "All right, start packing."

"What? Packing what now?"

"Wait, you haven't finished packing yet?"

Before the bewildered group could make sense of what he meant, he hit them with another thunderbolt.

"I said pack your things! The Zhuge Clan is leaving this place immediately!"

At that moment, a few of them thought that damn Family Head might have been better off getting assassinated in the privy.

Yet a smile they couldn't understand tugged at Zhuge Feng's lips as he dropped that bombshell.

May fortune be with you, Alliance Leader. And…

Just a little longer. Please, hold on just a little longer.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

With that desperate wish in his heart, Zhuge Feng gazed far to the west.

[3786] Emperor Zhaolie of Han was Liu Bei, the founding ruler of Shu Han.

[3787] Bashu is a historical name for the region around the Sichuan Basin, including parts of present-day Sichuan and Chongqing.

[3788] A Chinese *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi).

Chapter 1087

While Zhuge Feng gazed west with an earnest wish in his eyes, a low laugh rang out from the highest peak in the western lands.

“Good. This is how it should be. Exactly how it should be.”

At the Blood Lord’s smiling nod, the messenger who had just finished his report felt a quiet sense of relief.

He had brought news good enough to satisfy him.

Unlike his comrades, who had become cold corpses one after another, he wouldn’t be killed by the violent man before him.

But it was too soon to feel safe.

This hour wasn’t over yet.

“So they’re all just watching and waiting to see what happens?”

At the Blood Lord’s question, the messenger lowered himself further, prostrating himself before he answered.

“That is correct. The Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families are watching the situation and strengthening their defenses, but they have made no further moves.”

“They used to praise one another as chivalrous heroes. Now that the moment has come, they’re scared stiff.”

The Blood Lord’s smile deepened. Then a clear voice rang out from somewhere.

“Better a coward than an idiot like you. Don’t you think?”

The Blood Lord frowned despite himself when he saw who had spoken, but soon answered in a leisurely tone.

“Couldn’t agree more. Stupidity leads straight to incompetence. That must be why he entrusted this plan to me.”

“And taking the sorcerers under my command and starting this without my permission?”

“I’ve been entrusted with everything in Qinghai. Why would I need to consult a defeated general?”

The Grand Sorceress smiled coldly at the reminder of her failure in Gansu.

“Your eloquence has certainly improved. Last time, was it your head that got cut off instead of your arm? I suppose I should praise you for getting a little smarter.”

For an instant, the smile on the Blood Lord’s lips faded.

Ever since Sword Saint Mae Jonghak’s strike had taken one of his arms during the incident the Central Plains Murim called the Shaolin Bloodshed, it had become a sore point he could not bear to have touched.

That damned woman.

Of course, he had accomplished his mission well enough.

He had stolen the Green Jade Buddha Staff, the most important prize, and killed numerous Shaolin Temple martial monks, including the Abbot, Hong Dao, dealing the temple a devastating blow.

But despite the success, the wound to his pride from how it had happened showed no sign of healing.

Merely remembering that violet Sword Force sent a chill through him. The place it had severed still throbbed, even now that a new arm had taken its place.

And he still carried his anger toward one reckless young pup who had stood against him to the very end without the slightest fear.

“Shut your mouth, bitch. You weren’t even there, so you’ve got no right to talk about it.”

The Blood Lord’s voice sank low. The Grand Sorceress gave him a faint smile.

“Right. That’s what I regret most.”

What?

“If I’d been there, you never could’ve come out with that nonsense about losing after fighting the Sword Saint for hundreds of exchanges.”

“…!”

“Be honest. After a life-and-death duel with the Fire King—that violent old man—you fought the Sword Saint for hundreds of exchanges? You’ve got some nerve, lying to him like that.”

“You’re imagining things. I’ve always told him the truth.”

The Blood Lord replied as calmly as he could, but he knew better than anyone that the Grand Sorceress was right.

It was true.

He had lied to the Lord of Heaven about his final fight with Mae Jonghak.

The first time he had ever lied—and the last.

Why?

It was simple.

He had been furious, and afraid.

If he had known Mae Jonghak’s identity from the start, prepared for his arrival, and conserved his strength, he wouldn’t have lost his arm before lasting even three exchanges.

And if he had reported everything without leaving out a single detail, the master he trusted and worshiped like a god might have cast him aside.

But he believed in me. That’s enough.

The Blood Lord quietly settled his thoughts.

It didn’t matter what the Grand Sorceress said to his face.

Whether the Lord of Heaven truly believed him or had simply pretended not to know, he had made no issue of it—and he never would.

"Enough. Keep this up and I'll want to blow your head off."

At the Blood Lord's warning, his composure now restored, the Grand Sorceress shrugged.

"I doubt you could, but let's leave it there. We have important work ahead. I don't want to waste my strength."

The Blood Lord nodded without a word.

The two of them had snarled at each other without pause, as if they'd been enemies since a past life. But carrying out the mission their master had given them mattered more than anything else.

"As you've probably guessed, the Central Plains won't be able to interfere in Qinghai's affairs for now."

The Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League were still pushing west even as they spoke.

Of course, if the Murim Alliance gathered the Central Plains' strength and brought it all to bear, it could crush them in an instant. But with the Moving Formations shackling it, taking that first, heavy step would be difficult.

No—not just difficult. Nearly impossible.

Sending enough troops to save Qinghai would leave cracks in the Central Plains' solid wall of defense.

"So if they want to save Qinghai, they leave the Central Plains exposed. And if they want to defend it, they have to abandon Qinghai."

The Blood Lord's smile returned as he continued.

"Looks like all that effort we put into those Central Plains bandits has paid off. A perfect checkmate, wouldn't you say?"

Unlike him, the Grand Sorceress's lips did not move beneath her veil.

"Of course I know. That's why I regret it even more."

"Why regret it? It's only a matter of time before Xining, where they've gathered, is surrounded from both sides."

"Is that all?"

"Take complete control of Qinghai, then, if possible, secure Jin Taekyung according to further orders. Wasn't that what he instructed?"

The Grand Sorceress let out a hollow laugh at the Blood Lord's question.

"I take back what I said earlier. You're still just as stupid."

What?

"Don't you understand? If the Murim Alliance had moved this time, we could have taken the Central Plains Murim—or even everything he wants."

The Grand Sorceress stared straight at the Blood Lord through her fine veil and added quietly,

"The whole world."

"…!"

"You should have consulted me before making your decision. To waste those precious Magic Formations, each usable only twice, on something like this…"

A low hum rose.

Qi surged with her cold voice.

At that moment, the Grand Sorceress was truly furious.

Furious that the Blood Lord had moved so many troops without so much as a word of discussion with her.

In doing so, he had wasted the dozens of Magic Formations Dark Heaven had spent so long planting throughout the world—and missed a golden opportunity to take it.

Yet even as she seethed, the smile on the Blood Lord's lips did not disappear.

If anything, it grew even broader.

What?

The Grand Sorceress realized something was wrong a moment too late. The Blood Lord spoke with a sneer.

"I think you need to take back what you just said. Did you really think I was that stupid?"

"What are you talking about?"

"The Yangtze and the Green Forest. We recruited those mangy bandits as bait from the start. I never intended to put real effort into bait."

The Grand Sorceress's eyes widened as she grasped what he meant.

"Then perhaps…"

"That's right. It was for show. Though I wondered if the Central Plains might take the bait. Unless those fools are complete idiots, they've been on guard against Magic Formations for some time."

That was why he needed to test them.

Had the dozens of Magic Formations Dark Heaven's sorcerers secretly set up throughout the world been discovered?

And if not, did they still work?

"And now we know for certain."

The test had succeeded.

A total of ten thousand Dark Heaven faithful had crossed into the Central Plains through the Magic Formations and joined the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League. The Blood Lord had only just received the news.

From the messenger still unable to raise his head before them.

"Perfect. Unfortunately, a couple of the Magic Formations used when we attacked Shaolin may have lost their power, but most still have one use left."

The Grand Sorceress, who had fallen silent as she listened, murmured,

"That's enough. With that much…"

They wouldn't need to bring all of Dark Heaven's forces into play.

They could drop tens of thousands of troops into the heart of the Central Plains at once and bring down its major sects. A single great war would be enough to conquer the world.

But that alone could not quell all her anger.

The Grand Sorceress fixed the Blood Lord with a piercing gaze.

"I understand your reasons and your justification. But it's not enough."

"Why not?"

"We still have one last chance to activate the Magic Formations. But now they'll be even more wary of us."

"No. It's the other way around."

What?

"When bandits start rampaging all around them, wouldn't it be stranger if we did nothing to help or intervene?"

"…!"

"It was something we had to do anyway, if only to keep watch over those two bandit gangs in case they change their minds again."

If they could betray once, they could do it twice or three times.

The ten thousand Dark Heaven faithful sent ahead were also a deterrent against another betrayal.

Another shackle to keep the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League from entertaining other ideas.

To make sure they wouldn't even dare.

"No matter how this goes, we have nothing to lose."

The Blood Lord rose to his feet and continued,

"If the Central Plains' chivalrous heroes can't bear their guilt and rise from their seats, the Magic Formations will prove their worth."

Step. Step.

His voice scattered as his footsteps rang out slowly.

"And if they stay where they are, we'll pass through Qinghai and head into the Central Plains."

Rumble.

At the Blood Lord's outstretched hand, the massive iron doors swung open.

Below them stood a vast army, blackening the mountain range.

"Raise the army. We march on Xining."

Chapter 1088

I'd made it through more crises than I could count.

Even if I counted only the life-or-death situations I'd faced inside Gates, I had enough experience to rival any old hand in Murim.

So I knew one thing very well: the worse the situation, the more clearheaded I had to be.

And now, four days after arriving in Xining, clearheaded judgment and a few more pieces of information had finally led me to a conclusion.

"Mujin."

"Yes, sir. Just give the order."

Hyuk Mujin looked at me with blazing eyes and thumped his chest.

"Your reliable right-hand man is right here, Captain."

I addressed the guy who was more like a shabby little toe.

"I think we're fucked."

"Pardon?"

"I said I think we're fucked. For real."

"…Are you serious?"

The fire in his eyes went out as if someone had doused it with cold water, but I could only answer calmly.

"Yeah. Completely."

"But you weren't saying that a few days ago."

"I wasn't. Not at first."

But the situation had changed beyond recognition.

The Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance.

As if getting blindsided by those two bands of thieves wasn't enough, Potala Palace in Tibet had joined forces with Dark Heaven.

Potala Palace's rise at precisely this moment also meant we could no longer count on support from Sichuan.

And the Central Plains—

"Now that even the Great Nation's military vessels guarding the Yangtze's tributaries have been wiped out, the waterways through the Central Plains are practically in their hands for the time being."

I wanted to deny it, but I couldn't anymore.

A messenger eagle had arrived the night before, confirming the reports that Seafaring King Pa Ryun's Yangtze River Channel League pirates had scored an overwhelming victory against the Great Nation.

“Even if they suffered a crushing defeat this time, don’t they still have plenty of military vessels left? The Great Nation has more strength than that, and the Yangtze is huge.”

Mujin had a point.

The Great Nation wasn’t called great for nothing.

The battle with the Yangtze River Channel League had dealt it a terrible blow, but if that alone were enough to make it lose control of the entire Yangtze, it never could have claimed to rule the world in the first place.

The important thing, though, was—

“Time. Time is the problem, isn’t it?”

A familiar voice cut in.

Bow Saint emerged from behind Jeok Cheongang, who had appeared at some point.

“Even that little time they’ve gained will be more damaging to us than anything.”

Exactly.

Whether their reign lasted only three days or their glory faded as quickly as a flower, there was no way to stop the Yangtze River Channel League right now.

By the time the Great Nation invoked its authority to requisition every ship it could and gathered its naval forces from across the land, it would already be too late.

By then, Qinghai—no, Xining itself—would be completely surrounded, front and back.

“So how many of those damn bandits have gathered?”

I answered Jeok Cheongang.

“Our estimate so far is around thirty thousand.”

“Hah. They’re coming in packs like dogs. Then again, numbers are about the only thing those dark-path bastards have to brag about.”

“If it were just numbers, that would be much better. Take out their leaders, and the rest would collapse on its own.”

As was true everywhere, dark-path figures and unorthodox factions were especially dependent on the people at their center.

They gathered and scattered around individuals who became their leaders through overwhelming strength and the ability to command others.

Seafaring King Pa Ryun.

And Green Forest Battle King Tae Gunak.

If we took out those two Supreme Peak masters who embodied the dark path, the combined forces of the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance might not be such a difficult opponent.

Of course, that was only if no new uninvited guests showed up.

"Right, Dark Heaven. You said they'd joined them."

"Yes. Ten thousand of them. A full third of their forces."

Jeok Cheongang smacked his lips at my answer.

"They've put a tight leash on those two. Made sure they won't dare bare their teeth at their master."

"That's what makes it worse. Even if Pa Ryun and Tae Gunak are taken out now, their forces will still come after us."

"Of course. Those cowards have seen for themselves that the dark arts they'd only heard about are real. They'll tuck their tails between their legs even tighter."

Ten thousand enemies had appeared.

Right in the heart of the Central Plains.

The existence of Moving Formations had always worried the Central Plains Murim. Having that fear become reality was another matter entirely.

It seemed even great sects like the Zhuge Clan and Wudang couldn't ignore it.

Though they all but ruled Hubei's Murim, even they had chosen to avoid a direct confrontation.

I'd heard the Zhuge Clan had gone so far as to flee to Mount Wudang, leaving behind the family home where they'd put down roots for hundreds of years.

They're weaker than the other great sects, so I understand. But was that really the best choice?

I found myself thinking of Zhuge Feng, Family Head of the Zhuge Clan and the Crouching Dragon Guest.

We hadn't known each other all that long, but from what I'd seen of him while I was in Hubei, he was a good man.

Like a rock in a raging current, he was free-spirited yet steadfast, with the ability to back up that resolve.

And more than anything, he deserved to be called a Great Hero.

So why?

I wanted to ask.

Not in the privacy of my own thoughts, but to their faces.

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families. The many Sect Leaders and Family Heads of the orthodox factions.

The Murim Alliance—the single banner they had all raised together.

I wanted to look those people, who had never hesitated to call themselves righteous, straight in the eye and ask:

Was this the righteous path they were so proud of?

Was their so-called great cause the reason they couldn't stop the traitors heading west?

Crack.

The bones in my fist popped. I hadn't realized how tightly I'd clenched it.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been watching me with a somber gaze, spoke.

"Anyone can become a coward when faced with a crisis."

"I know."

I added quietly, remembering a past that still lingered like a scar.

"I've been one myself."

"It sounds like you're saying you'll never do it again."

"I promised myself."

"You must feel it in your bones, but even judging by what we know so far, their strength is beyond anything we imagined. If Xining is surrounded, we'll be in for a very difficult fight."

As if agreeing, Bow Saint nodded quietly. Both had reached heights martial artists could scarcely dream of, and yet even they had to consider the possibility of defeat. That was how dire things were.

"I told you before: anyone can become a coward in a crisis."

Jeok Cheongang fixed his deep gaze on me. His voice was low and steady.

"In a situation like this, not a soul under heaven could blame you for withdrawing to fight another day."

Withdraw to fight another day.

Mujin's eyes widened as he understood what Jeok Cheongang meant. Bow Saint stayed silent.

And I—

"Probably. No, definitely."

I met Jeok Cheongang's gaze and continued.

"Even if I withdrew to fight another day—no, if I ran away—they'd have no right to criticize me."

"Even if they did, it wouldn't matter. If anyone dared to criticize you, I'd personally rip out his tongue. If anyone pointed a finger at you, I'd turn it to ash."

"I know that too."

"Then?"

"I'm staying. Here."

At my calm reply, Jeok Cheongang's brow furrowed.

"Why?"

"Because if we leave, Qinghai is finished. The countless civilians staying in Xining won't even have time to escape."

"If we fight to the death here, it may not just be Qinghai that falls into their hands. It could be the whole world."

He wasn't being arrogant. He wasn't exaggerating.

The Three Saints and Ten Kings were symbols of the Murim world, and its strongest forces.

It was embarrassing to admit, but I, too, had become something of a symbol.

And a gap in our forces could lead straight to defeat.

As I fell silent, Jeok Cheongang went on with something like a sigh.

“The world has already looked away. The Nine Sects and One Gang, the Five Great Families, the Murim Alliance—they’ve all turned their backs. And you still mean to make such a foolish choice?”

That was when I finally parted my tightly closed lips.

“Even so, we have to.”

“What?”

“No. Because everyone has turned away and abandoned us, we have to do it even more.”

Jade is beautiful even as it shatters.

The light it gives off as it breaks into dozens of pieces is more brilliant than ever.

That is jade shattering.

That is why it is called jade shattering.

It is so brilliant, you forget the word *destruction*.

Because it breaks rather than be defiled.

“Have you ever seen jade covered in filth and dust?”

Jeok Cheongang stared at me, eyes wide. I continued, slowly but clearly.

“I haven’t. But I know that jade already covered in filth loses its value, at least for a while.”

Even then, the jade’s true nature doesn’t disappear.

It might look like nothing but filth, but the light is still hidden within it.

Yet no one who sees its beautiful surface covered in grime will want to touch it.

Not unless a sudden downpour washes the jade clean.

Not unless someone who remembers what it looks like finds it and carefully wipes it off.

So—

“Better to break than to be defiled.”

“…!”

“…!”

“…!”

I felt the air tremble and let out the breath I’d been holding.

Yes. This was right.

Even if it ended in death, I couldn’t let that original brilliance fade.

I had to make everyone remember. I had to make them realize what mattered most—the thing they'd briefly forgotten amid excuses about the great cause and fears of what they might lose.

The jade called justice.

And I would do everything in my power to protect it.

I wouldn't break. I wouldn't be defiled.

There was still far too much to do before I faced that brilliant final moment.

The greatest, strongest wall casting its shadow over the world was still standing.

The Lord of Heaven.

Just then, as the meaning of those two words rang through my heart and drew nearer than ever, Jeok Cheongang—head bowed, lost in thought amid the heavy silence—suddenly spoke.

"You asked whether I'd ever seen jade covered in filth and dust?"

He muttered as if speaking to himself, then raised his head.

Though his body had grown young again, a familiar face was reflected in eyes that held the weight of his years.

"Yes. I saw it. I remember it very clearly."

He looked at me.

His gaze, drawn back to that day in the not-so-distant past, began to shine.

"That was when I realized how brilliant a light the mangy, weak little whelp in front of me was carrying."

"…!"

"I told you, didn't I? If anyone dared to criticize you or point a finger at you, I'd personally punish them. But do you know something?"

The furrows between his brows deepened.

With a clear smile on his face, he slowly reached out and rested a hand on my shoulder.

"If you'd made the same choice as them, I never would have forgiven you."

Bow Saint spoke with a faint smile.

"Unfortunately, that won't be happening. Your Disciple is far too good for that."

A laugh escaped me before I knew it.

Yeah. That was probably true.

The Jeok Cheongang I knew had been that sort of person from the start.

First, he'd go find everyone who insulted his one and only Disciple and beat them to a pulp. Then he'd use whatever strength he had left to give his idiot Disciple a thorough beating.

"Looks like you'll have to use that strength somewhere else."

Jeok Cheongang laughed out loud at that.

“That’s the plan. I’ll squeeze out every last drop of strength I’ve got.”
And before half a day had passed, his words became reality.

Chapter 1089

As the hour of the Rooster[3789] began, an old beggar watched the sun inch toward the western mountains and muttered to himself.

“How strange. It’s not time for the sun to set yet.”

The other beggars huddled around a nearby campfire reacted to his words.

“Then what about weather like this at this time of year? Does that make sense?”

“Right. It’s not like this just started yesterday or the day before.”

“Branch Master, don’t stand out there in the cold wind. Come warm yourself by the fire. Have a bowl of hot soup, too.”

They had a point. The world hadn’t gone haywire just yesterday.

The old beggar—Man Chong, Branch Master of the Beggars’ Sect’s Xining branch in Qinghai—sighed and walked toward the fire.

Gung Gibang, the Successor Beggar, had returned to Xining several days ago. Man Chong, however, had stayed behind with around thirty Beggars’ Sect disciples under his command to gather information.

“Got anything to eat?”

“Of course. We may not have a damn thing to our names, but we always find a way to fill our bellies.”

“You saved some for the ones out on patrol?”

“Come now. Do you take us for beggars with no decency? Don’t worry. There’s enough for them to come back and eat till they burst.”

One of the beggars grinned, yellow teeth showing, and offered him a steaming bowl. Man Chong found himself smacking his lips.

“That smells incredible.”

“Just eat it. You’ll see it tastes as good as it smells.”

He was right.

Man Chong emptied the bowl in no time, then patted his full belly with a satisfied smile.

It looked like a hodgepodge if ever there was one, but perhaps because it was made with fish freshly caught in Qinghai Lake, it tasted like the work of a first-rate chef.

Well, I’m old. I deserve a little luxury like this.

Drowsy with contentment, Man Chong picked his teeth with a fish bone and looked around.

As he watched the waters of Qinghai Lake slowly take on the colors of the sunset, he felt his worries wash away, if only for a moment.

[3789] The hour of the Rooster is the traditional two-hour period from about 5 to 7 p.m.

Reality, of course, was still bleak.

What good are a pretty view and a full belly? I can't sleep easy until those bastards are gone.

Dark Heaven. At the thought of those terrifying Fiends, a shadow fell over Man Chong's face.

The situation had hardly improved since Jin Taekyung and the reinforcements passed through here to join the others in Xining about four days ago.

No—it was getting worse by the day, as if to crush that brief glimmer of hope.

At this rate, we'll be surrounded from both sides for sure… Damn it. We're caught in a hell of a mess.

The mere thought of Dark Heaven's massive army occupying Kunlun Mountain sent a chill down his spine. And from the rear, bandits who'd dealt the Central Plains Murim a vicious blow were said to be swarming in like ants.

There was only one thing they had going for them: Dark Heaven's main force had yet to make a serious move.

But that's only a matter of time. They're coming, and soon.

The fullness in his belly vanished. Anxiety and fear took its place.

"…Damn it."

His mood souring in an instant, Man Chong snatched up a pebble within reach and hurled it.

Whoosh!

His clothes were shabby, but he was a seasoned Branch Master and a master of the Beggars' Sect.

The pebble shot from his fingertips toward the endless expanse of Qinghai Lake.

Splash!

The water split violently. Only then did the tightness in his chest ease a little. Man Chong snorted and turned away.

Or tried to.

He stopped when the ripples from the pebble settled and the water slowly grew still again.

What is it?

It didn't take him long to place the sudden sense of déjà vu.

The color. The color of the water…

It was dark.

No—as black as if someone had poured ink into it.

Only moments ago, the waters of Qinghai Lake had glowed with the sunset. Now there was nothing beautiful about them, and even the quiet conversation behind him sounded strangely ominous.

"Man, why's it getting dark so fast today? Usually the sunset alone lasts half an hour."

"What can we do about it? It is what it is. Have some more food before the patrol comes back."

"Don't mind if I do. Branch Master, would you like another bowl?"

Man Chong didn't answer. More precisely, he couldn't.

At that moment, his instincts were sounding a red alarm in his head.

Something's… wrong.

Of course, it could be nothing, as the other Beggars' Sect disciples seemed to think.

Frost had fallen before harvest season, and giant monsters that barely looked human were running wild. What was left to be surprised by?

But he had a feeling he couldn't explain. More than sixty years of experience—and an old veteran's instinct, etched into his bones.

"The patrol. When are they due back?"

"Huh? Why do you ask all of a sudden?"

"Answer me. Now!"

The old Branch Master was usually so easygoing that his sudden bark left the disciples stammering.

"Th-they should be back soon."

"W-well, they're about half a gak[3790] later than usual, but they must be close by now. There's no need to worry, Branch Master… Huh?"

One of the disciples trailed off, eyes widening as he looked over Man Chong's shoulder. Everyone turned.

On a low hill about two hundred zhang[3791] away, a group of men and horses had just appeared, tiny as specks. They were slowly descending through the gathering darkness.

"Speak of the devil. There they are."

"Look at those lazy bastards. They're already late, and now they're taking their sweet time?"

"Branch Master, stay put. I'll give them a proper scolding this time."

As everyone tossed out remarks while watching Man Chong's expression, he stared at the patrol with sunken eyes and muttered,

"Twelve."

"What?"

"Twelve. Unless my eyes are playing tricks on me."

"What does that—"

[3790] A *gak* is a traditional time division of about fifteen minutes; half a gak is about seven and a half minutes.

[3791] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The disciple's question died on his lips.

The patrol that had left to survey the area about two shichen[3792] ago had numbered ten.

"Th-that means…"

"Could be one of two things. Either they found survivors who made it through by sheer luck…"

Man Chong drew the iron staff, worn smooth from years of handling, from his waist and added quietly,

"Or some sons of bitches who deserve to be chewed up alive are pretending to be the patrol."

"…!"

"Get to the boat now. We'll raise anchor, put some distance between us, then see what happens."

"Y-yes, Branch Master!"

At last grasping the danger, the disciples moved as one.

By the time they'd boarded the boat moored by the shore and rowed far enough away, the mysterious group—friend or foe, they couldn't tell—had reached the campfire they'd left behind.

"Seok Sam! Seok Sam, are you there?"

Man Chong's sudden shout was answered from beyond the darkness, which had grown noticeably deeper.

"I'm here! What is it?"

In that instant, Man Chong's face went rigid.

So did every other Beggars' Sect disciple's. Not one of those staying at Qinghai Lake could have spoken down to Man Chong, their Branch Master and the oldest among them.

Worse, the voice from the darkness sounded exactly like Seok Sam's.

"B-Branch Master…"

Leaving the Beggars' Sect disciples behind, their faces pale as if they'd seen a ghost, Man Chong gritted his teeth and shouted again.

"Who are you bastards?"

For a moment, silence fell.

It lasted only a moment, but felt longer than ever—like an eternity.

Then an unfamiliar voice suddenly rang out, shattering the silence that seemed ready to suffocate them.

"Well, I guess beggar bastards are quick on the uptake."

[3792] A *shichen* is a traditional two-hour period; two shichen are about four hours.

With a buoyant voice that even carried a hint of laughter, the figure that had only been a silhouette emerged into view, heading for the still-burning campfire.

Tap-tap.

Amid the sparks rising into the air, a man and horse crossed the gravel without the slightest sound. Man Chong's eyes widened.

"W-what is that…?"

For a moment, he couldn't speak.

The horse was a skeleton, its white bones exposed. But it was the man seated so casually on its back who filled him with a fear unlike anything he'd ever known.

The man grinned, baring unnaturally white teeth and fangs as sharp as a wild beast's.

His blood-red eyes gleamed even at this distance. Just meeting his gaze felt as though it bound Man Chong's body and mind.

"Y-you…"

The man shrugged at the trembling Man Chong.

"You know who I am, more or less."

His nonchalance only made him more terrifying. Man Chong forced out a question.

"The patrol… What happened to them?"

"Aw. How touching. All that begging together must have made you close."

"You bastard! Answer me!"

"How am I supposed to talk with a beggar yelling at me? Fine, fine. Don't get so worked up."

The man waved a hand as though calming him down, then smacked his lips.

"To sum it up, they've gone to a better place. Didn't taste like much, though."

"W-what did you say?"

Man Chong froze, his mind settling on a suspicion too horrible to put into words. The man frowned.

"Hey, don't get the wrong idea. Maybe it's because they were mangy beggar bastards, but their bodies weren't much to write home about either. I only drank a little blood, just to have some fun."

"…!"

"What? Was that not good enough for you? I thought I got the voice pretty close."

Grit.

The pungent scent of blood filled Man Chong's mouth. Even so, he clenched his teeth with all his strength.

It wasn't only rage at losing a subordinate who had been like a brother to him. He had to do this—had to hold on somehow—to bear the fear tightening its grip on him with every passing moment.

Dark arts.

Never had those words felt so chilling.

Nor had he ever felt as if his head could be severed at any moment by someone standing a hundred zhang[3793] away.

“So you’re the one. The leader we’ve heard about.”

“Well, let’s say I am. At least here, that person has entrusted everything to me.”

The man—the Blood Lord—smiled at Man Chong.

Then he slowly swept his gaze over the twenty Beggars’ Sect disciples, frozen like statues around him, and spoke.

“So, who’ll it be?”

“What?”

“I’m planning to let at least one of you live. One of you gets to survive, and I get someone to deliver a message. Good for both sides, isn’t it?”

“…!”

“Look at your faces. What, did you think you could just run away?”

The Blood Lord grinned at their rigid faces a hundred zhang[3794] away, then turned to look behind him.

“Time to get moving, isn’t it? It’s something we have to do anyway.”

At his words, one of the figures waiting in the darkness stepped forward.

Swish.

Long robes brushed the gravel. As if the Blood Lord weren’t worth answering, the Grand Sorceress passed him, reached the lakeshore, and extended her hand.

“Cold north wind…”

Wooooom.

The air trembled. A vast chill swept across Qinghai Lake.

And then, they saw it.

“Freeze.”

Crack-crack-crack!

With a crack of ice, Qinghai Lake froze white.

“…!”

“…!”

Man Chong and all twenty Beggars’ Sect disciples stared, wide-eyed.

A miracle that should not—and could not—exist.

Faced with that impossible sight, they could do nothing.

Not even when the foul stench of monsters began to drift toward them from beyond the thick darkness in the distance.

[3793] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3794] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Not when the Blood Lord crossed the frozen lake as casually as if out for a stroll, climbed onto the bow of their boat, and looked down at them.

“Whoever survives, go tell them. I—the Blood Lord—am coming.”

At that moment, Man Chong forced out his voice with everything he had.

“You’ll never win—”

Crunch!

Scarlet blood sprayed across the white ice.

“So, have you decided who gets to survive?”

In the cold, deep night, the Blood Lord’s blood-red eyes gleamed.

Chapter 1090

Qinghai was unquestionably a border region.

It was among the largest provinces in the world and had some of the most beautiful scenery, but its supplies and households were nowhere near as plentiful as those of the Central Plains.

So whenever people compared Qinghai to the Central Plains—which had stood at the center of the world for thousands of years and developed its culture in every direction—the people of Qinghai liked to joke:

"Qinghai and the Central Plains have only three things in common. They see the same sun, they're connected by the same water—the Yellow River—and they both have beggars."

Beggars were common everywhere, after all.

They lived along busy main roads, in dark, filthy alleys, and in shantytowns beside streams. It made no difference whether they were in the Central Plains or out on the border.

There were so many that people joked the Beggars' Sect could found a nation of its own if it took in every beggar under heaven.

But near daybreak, a scouting party searching through the faint morning mist came across a white-haired beggar unlike any they had ever seen.

No—there was something so strange about him that it made the fine hairs on their bodies stand up.

Step. Step.

He staggered as though he might collapse at any moment. His eyes were empty, as if his soul had left his body.

And then…

"Tell them. Without fail. Whoever survives."

His voice trembled with terror as it slipped between his blue lips.

Perhaps that was why the scouts stood frozen for a moment before they noticed the two knots tied at the beggar's waist.

"…The Beggars' Sect."

There was no mistaking it. The beggar before them was a Beggars' Sect martial artist.

A two-knot disciple, just one rank below a Branch Master.

And as far as they knew, there was only one reason a Beggars' Sect disciple would appear here, a hundred li[3795] west of Xining, where the scouts had set out from.

"Old man, what on earth happened at Qinghai Lake—"

[3795] In China, one li is 500 m (0.311 mi). A hundred li is about 50 km (31 mi).

One scout hurriedly dismounted and started toward him, then caught his breath and stared.

Only then did he see it.

Through the pale mist, the disciple's hair had looked white with age. In truth, it was frozen stiff, like the hair of someone trapped in a glacier.

And the face turned white beneath it belonged not to an old man, but to a young one.

"W-what is this…?"

Was this what it felt like to have a bolt of lightning strike through the crown of your head?

All twenty scouts fell silent, a chill running down their spines.

They had no idea that the disciple's next words would be the last spark of his life, spoken with every ounce of strength he had left.

"Tell them. I'm coming. I'll go to Xining and kill and burn everything there."

"…!"

"…!"

For an instant, the scouts trembled, their eyes wide with shock.

Because of the terrifying killing intent in those words?

No. That wasn't it.

The Beggars' Sect disciple was smiling. And crying at the same time.

As though imitating whoever had ordered him to deliver the message.

As though grieving for the comrades who were already dead.

Then, in the suffocating silence that pressed down on them all, his body tilted. His difficult journey had come to an end, and his voice had grown faint.

"Just wait. I, the Blood Lord, have returned—"

Thud.

His body crumpled like a rotten log.

The scouts stared blankly at the Beggars' Sect disciple's corpse. Then, all at once, they raised their heads and looked west.

Why?

Was it the fear already taking root in their hearts, or an instinctive sense of what they were about to face?

Beyond the thick mist, they could almost hear the shrieks of hideous monsters and smell their stench.

"…See to his body."

The commander had to force the words out, and even then his voice couldn't hide his fear.

"We're going back to Xining. Right now."

The office of the Qinghai City Lord—now a headless corpse—was as impossibly spacious and luxurious as ever.

As though it existed to prove why he'd had to die.

Its expensive ebony table was large enough to seat dozens of people at once. He had even used Shu brocade, prized as a first-rate luxury in Sichuan, to keep out the sunlight.

But the City Lord could never have known that the gaudy luxuries he'd treasured until his death would now be put to use for a shabby beggar.

"Enjoying this kind of luxury when you're only a two-knot disciple. You forgot what it means to be a beggar."

Gung Gibang muttered, doing his best to sound calm.

The corpse lay on the ebony table, wrapped in Shu brocade. Gung Gibang's eyes glistened as he looked at it.

"I didn't know him long, but he was a good kid. Still young, and already talented enough to be granted the second knot."

I said nothing.

Neither did any of the other leaders gathered in the office.

"He asked if he could visit the Central Plains someday, once things got better. I snapped at him for saying something so childish… Damn it."

Gung Gibang swore in a hollow voice and gave a bitter smile.

"What can you do? He and the others were just unlucky."

Nearly thirty Beggars' Sect disciples had been left on the other side of Qinghai Lake. Only one young, nameless disciple had made it back to Xining.

And even he had died along the way.

He'd been in such a terrible state that the scouts who found him could barely speak.

But his final words, which might as well have been a will, contained information more valuable than this entire goddamn lavish office.

"The Blood Lord. If it's the Blood Lord…"

I nodded at the murmur from Cheongheoja, the Kunlun Sect Leader.

"It's the same one you're thinking of, Sect Leader. The one behind the Shaolin Bloodshed."

"…!"

"…!"

An invisible ripple passed through the room.

Those who already knew of the Blood Lord let out low murmurs without a word. Those who hadn't known the details stared in shock.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, belonged to neither group.

“A name I’ve longed to hear again.”

His voice was quiet, his expression barely changed.

But I knew better than anyone how furious Jeok Cheongang was.

And how hard he was fighting to hold that fury back.

“Now I can hold my head up in front of that damned monk.”

Hong Dao had been the Abbot of Shaolin Temple, known as the Mount Tai and Northern Dipper of the Murim,[3796] and respected enough to earn the title of Dharma King. Yet Jeok Cheongang had always called him “that damned monk.”

He’d been one of the very few friends Jeok Cheongang had ever had. Maybe the only one.

There was no way Jeok Cheongang had forgotten, even for a moment, his grudge against the man who had killed Hong Dao.

But right now, there was something more pressing than his grudge.

“So they mean to throw everything they have into this after all.”

A young Daoist spoke in a voice so calm it almost sounded cold. Hak Eui, Cheongheoja’s second Disciple, continued.

“They went to the trouble of releasing a Beggars’ Sect disciple they’d already captured. That must mean they’re certain they’ll win.”

“S-second brother.”

Hak Su, his Senior Brother, had been watching the room uneasily and tried to stop him. Hak Eui paid him no mind.

He’d gained a measure of influence since the last meeting about the Qinghai City Lord.

“But it’s unfortunate we didn’t receive the most important information. If we’d known even the enemy’s numbers, we could have made a much better plan—”

“What?”

Gung Gibang, who had been staring at the corpse in silence, suddenly scowled.

“What did you just say?”

Hak Eui answered his anger evenly.

“I was only expressing my thoughts out of regret.”

“So what? Are you blaming a man who risked his life for everyone and died? Asking why he didn’t try harder?”

“That’s…”

Hak Eui was about to respond when someone who had been watching quietly spoke up.

“Second.”

[3796] Mount Tai and the Northern Dipper are used together in a Chinese honorific for a widely revered authority in a field.

His Master, Cheongheoja.

Hak Eui paused at the quiet call, then bowed his head to Gung Gibang.

“I spoke carelessly because I’m inexperienced. I hope there will be no further misunderstanding.”

There was little feeling in the stiff apology. Gung Gibang’s expression darkened further, but Cheongheoja spoke again.

“I failed to raise my Disciple properly. I sincerely apologize.”

This was no ordinary apology. It came from a far more senior martial artist, and the Sect Leader of the Kunlun Sect at that.

There were others present who outranked even him.

No matter that Gung Gibang was the Beggars’ Sect Successor Beggar, prolonging the argument now could be seen as a grave act of disrespect.

I watched him bite his lip, then looked at Hak Eui. At the right moment, I sent Gung Gibang a Sound Transmission.

—Let it go. For now.

“…!”

—Or I can beat that socially maladjusted bastard half to death right now. Just tell me which you’d prefer.

At last, Gung Gibang gave a bitter smile and shook his head.

“Understood. I’m sorry for souring the mood, too.”

That brought the brief commotion to an end. Hak Eui spoke again, without the slightest sign of having been cowed.

“Fortunately, we still have time before the enemy reaches Xining. We should come up with adequate defenses before then.”

There was something odd about his tone.

I’d been watching him all along with a somber gaze. Now I couldn’t help asking,

“What preparations?”

“You already know, Great Hero Jin.”

Of course I did. I knew all too well.

That was what made it so surprising—that Hak Eui, heir to the Kunlun Sect’s Daoist lineage, would suggest it.

“It’s not too late. We must leave this place at once, before the route behind us is completely cut off.”

“Junior Brother, what are you saying?”

Hak Su sprang to his feet, unable to hold back any longer. Even Cheongheoja let out a troubled murmur. Hak Eui still didn’t stop.

“This isn’t a battle. It’s a war. I know it isn’t right to say this, but… we can’t make the mistake of clinging to something small and losing everything.”

“…!”

"…!"

The air in the room froze.

Then I spoke.

"Uh, first of all, there's too much bullshit there to answer point by point. So let's start with this."

I looked at Hak Eui's rigid face and added quietly.

"Does the Blood Lord look like a pushover to you?"

I pointed at the table.

More precisely, at the Beggars' Sect disciple's corpse, lying there with frost on patches of his body.

I'd known from the moment I first saw him.

That terrible cold still lingering in his dead body. I recognized its familiar trace—one only I could detect.

Blizzard.

A highest-tier ice spell with devastating power.

It meant two things.

First, just as I'd expected, the Grand Sorceress was with them.

And second—

"They've already crossed Qinghai Lake."

They wouldn't have needed boats. They could simply walk across the lake, frozen solid by magic.

The Blood Lord had only released the Beggars' Sect disciple for his own amusement in the first place.

"So," I said quietly to Hak Eui, whose expression I couldn't read, "if you want to run, leave now. You cowardly bastard."

And at that moment—

Rrrk. Rrrrrk.

A tremor came from somewhere, and the office began to shake.

No—the whole of Xining.

Chapter 1091

Xining, the capital of Qinghai, stood on a vast plateau.

Tributaries of the Yellow River flowed to its east and west, stretching all the way to the Central Plains. Mountains large and small surrounded the city, making for a view beautiful enough to draw gasps from anyone who saw it.

But at that moment, not one of the countless people crowding Xining's high walls could think the view before them was beautiful.

It wasn't that they failed to appreciate it. They couldn't.

A mountain that should have stood tall and still, as it always had, was moving. The sight alone was enough to send a chill down their spines.

Rrrk. Rrrrk.

A tremendous rumble unlike anything they had ever felt.

The whole city shook with it. So did its people, body and soul.

And at the end of all those gazes, filled with undisguised horror, was a pitch-black mountain drawing closer from the distance.

No—an army moving like a single mountain.

Dark Heaven.

At last, they had come.

Fiends from beyond the desert, come to blacken the blue sky and green earth alike.

I couldn't have been the only one who felt as though the world had suddenly grown dark.

It was dark everywhere.

Clouds hid the sun, and a chill that swallowed its light filled the space it left behind.

And.

At the center of it all, they stood.

Dark Heaven's vast army of monsters and humans.

"…Benefactor."

Cheongpung had come up onto the wall at some point. His voice was lower than usual, with a faint tremor in it, but I didn't answer.

More precisely, I couldn't.

I was overwhelmed, too, by the sight of the enemy advancing beyond the wall, filling everything in view.

I couldn't let anyone see that. Not ever.

But even if I could fool the whole world, there was one person I couldn't fool.

—Are you afraid?

At Jeok Cheongang's Sound Transmission in my ear, I quietly bit my lip.

Yes. I am.

At this moment, I was terrified enough to shudder.

Their strength was far greater than I'd imagined. And the moment I saw them for what they truly were, the word *defeat* had come to me by instinct. That frightened me.

Squeeze.

Warmth spread through the fist I'd clenched without realizing it. I curled my fingers tighter to keep the beads of blood from slipping between them, and answered.

—Yes. I'm afraid.

—What are you so afraid of?

—Myself, most of all. I made up my mind. I prepared for this. And I still shrank back. I'm afraid of what might happen because of that.

I wouldn't claim I wasn't afraid of dying.

That would deny every desperate struggle I'd made to survive. It would be laughable hypocrisy.

But I feared something far more: the hundreds of thousands of lives behind this wall being lost because I'd made the wrong choice.

Because of me, and no one else.

Jeok Cheongang saw right through me.

—Yes. That's the difference between you and this old man.

Before I could ask what he meant, his next Sound Transmission reached me.

—Not once in my life have I pursued some grand cause. I simply went where my feet took me, where the wind blew. The deaths of strangers I'd never met didn't trouble me much.

People saw Jeok Cheongang as the foremost of the Ten Kings, one of the great figures of the orthodox faction. But the truth was different.

He was a free man.

Like the Sect Leaders of the Fire Gate Clan before him, he belonged to none of the orthodox, unorthodox, or demonic factions. He had walked only his own path.

—Perhaps that's why the title of Great Hero, which stuck to me before I knew it, always felt like clothes that didn't fit.

—But you deserve to be called one.

—No. That's wrong.

Jeok Cheongang answered firmly and fixed me with a deep, searching gaze.

—Only someone who fears the pain of others and knows how to shed tears deserves to be called a Great Hero. Someone like you.

—…!

—But remember one thing. If you don’t want to shed tears later, you must first overcome the fear in front of you.

Then Jeok Cheongang added quietly,

—Only then do you become a hero.

A hero. A hero, huh.

I mouthed those two words in my mind. They had always felt so far away. Then I gave a bitter smile.

—I never wanted to be one.

—That doesn’t matter. Wanting to be a hero isn’t what makes you one. You earn the title when the world calls you one.

—Like how they call you a Great Hero, Old Master?

—What?

—You just said it yourself. You never went out of your way to pursue a grand cause. You went where your feet took you, where the wind blew—and before you knew it, people were calling you a Great Hero.

—…!

Jeok Cheongang stared at me, eyes wide. Then he licked his lips.

—You got me with that one.

—Let’s call it even.

—You haven’t lost your knack for running that mouth. Now you’re finally starting to feel like the little hellion I knew.

Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet laugh and gestured with his chin beyond the wall.

—Well? Still afraid?

—Yes.

I answered without hesitation, then added calmly,

—But I won’t look away from that fear.

Everyone carries fear somewhere in their heart.

But only those who admit it and face it head-on can find the strength to stand against it.

Just as I was doing now.

Rumble. Rrrumble!

The rumbling grew stronger by the moment, and the ground shook as if an earthquake had struck.

I felt the powerful vibrations travel up the tall, sturdy wall and through my whole body.

At the same time, I saw him.

At the head of the enemy forces, so numerous I couldn't begin to count them, one man was grinning as he looked straight at us.

The Blood Lord.

He looked quite different from the last time I'd seen him, but the moment I saw that crooked smile, I knew by instinct.

The thick killing intent and madness about him seemed as though they'd rub off if I touched him. Even the Blood-Sword Demon Lord I'd defeated in Gansu couldn't compare.

And in the instant we recognized each other, his lips moved.

"Looking up at you is a pain in the neck. Why don't you come down for a bit and say hello?"

His words rang out through the deafening rumble and clouds of dust. Jeok Cheongang, who had already been staring hard at the Blood Lord, had a reddish gleam in his eyes.

"I was itching for a fight anyway. How kind of him to offer."

The Bow Saint immediately sensed what was coming and tried to stop him.

"He's baiting you. It couldn't be more obvious."

At her look for support, the Slaughter Saint, who had appeared out of nowhere and taken up a place on the wall, calmly nodded.

"Yeah, it's crazy."

Jeok Cheongang furrowed his brow. The Slaughter Saint added,

"Then again, no one here is in their right mind."

As Jeok Cheongang's brow smoothed, I delivered my solemn verdict.

"Let's do it now."

"Right. It's not like we'll die or anything."

Whoosh!

There wasn't even time for anyone to stop us.

Reciting the number-one last words of men everywhere, the three of us sprang off the wall together.

Behind us came the sharpest, loudest shout I'd ever heard from the Bow Saint.

"I told you not to go!"

Uh.

Sorry.

The moment he saw three figures hurtling across the distant sky toward him, the Blood Lord muttered without realizing it,

“They’re crazy. They’re actually coming?”

He’d only tossed out a casual remark. After a few words between them, he hadn’t expected them to charge straight at him without a moment’s hesitation.

“What are they, half-mad fighting dogs…?”

The Blood Lord trailed off, more than a little taken aback. By then, the three men had closed to a dozen or so zhang[3797], moving like flashes of light. They spoke at once.

“You told us to come down, you son of a bitch.”

“You’re lower than a dog. You goddamned bastard. Burning you alive wouldn’t be enough, you miserable—”

“So you’re the Blood Lord I’ve heard about. I know this is a strange request for a first meeting, but would you mind calmly offering your neck and stepping aside?”

First came Jin Taekyung, whose curses had an oddly satisfying ring to them. Then Jeok Cheongang, hurling every obscenity he knew. And finally the Slaughter Saint, whom the Blood Lord was meeting for the first time.

For a moment, surprise had covered the Blood Lord’s anger. Now he felt it surge back to the surface.

“Are you done talking?”

At the Blood Lord’s low voice, Jin Taekyung hesitated briefly and glanced at the Slaughter Saint.

“Anything else you’d like to say?”

“Probably not. We’ve only just met, so I don’t have much to say.”

The Slaughter Saint had already been remarkably rude for someone meeting him for the first time, but Jin Taekyung merely nodded and answered the Blood Lord.

“This one says he’s done.”

Crack.

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth at that nonchalant response and opened his mouth.

Or tried to.

Before he could, another wave of obscenities swept over him.

“I’ll grind down every last bone in your body. I’ll toss your flesh to the Nanman Beast Palace for feed, then scatter your remains in the Shaolin Temple latrines, and—”

“Ah, this one isn’t done yet. Give him a moment. Honestly, aren’t you a little curious what comes next?”

At that moment, the Blood Lord’s last thread of reason snapped. His vision went white.

“Hah!”

[3797] A zhang is a traditional measure of length, roughly 3 m (9.8 ft); its exact length varied historically.

KWA-A-A!

A powerful wave of qi swept out in every direction.

The immense internal energy packed into that single shout made Dark Heaven's seemingly endless army and the people on the wall a hundred or so zhang[3798] away hold their breath.

But the three men closest to him, who felt the full force of it, were the exception.

Whoosh!

A single sharp gust cut through the billowing dust.

At its center, Jin Taekyung had already slashed down with his clear, almost transparent spearhead. He grinned.

Just as the Blood Lord had before they came down from the wall.

"Why are you getting so worked up? I'm just glad to see you after all this time."

An explosion meant destruction. Destruction, in turn, was bound up with Erasure.

The Blood Lord had gathered his anger and unleashed it all at once. Now he stared at Jin Taekyung with eyes gone cold.

"You're just the same as before. That damned mouth of yours."

The smile vanished from Jin Taekyung's lips.

"This time will be different. Everything else will be."

[3798] A zhang is a traditional measure of length, roughly 3 m (9.8 ft); its exact length varied historically.

Chapter 1092

To a martial artist, a wave of qi was power made manifest.

Jin Taekyung could feel that more clearly than ever now. He could feel just how terrifyingly powerful the enemy before him was.

Rumble.

The air refused to settle beneath the force of the Blood Lord's qi. Faint tremors came from every direction, but Taekyung's mind grew calm enough for him to answer evenly, despite the cold fire in the Blood Lord's voice and gaze.

"You're just the same as before. That damned mouth of yours."

Taekyung let his smile fade. He raised his beloved spear, White Flame, and pointed it at the Blood Lord.

"This time will be different. Everything else will be."

"Different? Ha!"

Now it was the Blood Lord's turn to laugh. He eyed Taekyung with open contempt.

"I heard the Hidden Dragon had become a Divine Dragon, but you're acting like you've gotten your hands on a dragon pearl, too. Struggle all you want. You're still no match for me. You know that yourself, don't you?"

To the Blood Lord's surprise, Taekyung nodded readily.

"Yeah. Probably."

"What?"

"Why the reaction? Shouldn't you be a little happy I admitted it so honestly?"

"…You."

The Blood Lord's voice dropped, but Taekyung spoke before he could continue.

"I knew as soon as I saw you. I couldn't tell exactly how strong you were."

Even stones scattered along a roadside varied in size and shape. Why wouldn't mountains tall enough to touch the clouds vary in height?

Taekyung had climbed from the very bottom of the Murim to the heights of Supreme Peak. The moment he came face-to-face with the Blood Lord, he understood.

"You're stronger than me. No question."

He didn't know exactly how wide the gap was. But even if it was only one move—or half a move—Jin Taekyung accepted that the Blood Lord was the stronger one.

He remembered his not-so-distant past, when he'd been no better than an ant, helpless beneath a power so immense it felt absolute. Back then, the Blood Lord had seemed as unreachable as someone above the clouds.

"But you know what?"

Taekyung held the Blood Lord's gaze as he asked the question quietly.

Past and present overlapped before his eyes. Alongside the knowledge that the Blood Lord was stronger came another realization, running down his spine like an electric current.

“Back then, I thought I could fight with everything I had and still never touch a hair on your head…”

His voice trailed off, and he smiled.

Only today had he understood. The Blood Lord whose mere presence had once left him struggling to breathe was no longer beyond the clouds.

“Now I feel like I could reach you just by stretching out my hand.”

“…!”

The Blood Lord’s eyes widened. A dozen or so zhang[3799] away, Taekyung’s figure wavered like a mirage.

Fshh.

His shape remained, but his body was gone. There wasn’t even a trace of his presence, yet the killing intent within it was unmistakable.

Whooosh!

The Blood Lord heard the eerie sound clearly, as though the wind itself were howling.

At the same instant, he saw it.

Space warped under immense pressure. With Shifting Form and Position brought to its pinnacle, a spearhead outran sound and tore through the compressed air.

“Jin Taekyung!”

And then—

KWA-A-A!

The Blood Lord’s furious shout and the muffled boom of a sonic blast rang out as a blood-red flash clashed with a dark-blue wave, swallowing the world around them.

One exchange.

A single exchange was enough to show me the gap between the Blood Lord and me.

KRRRACK!

The Blood Lord swung his Red Blade like lightning, and it locked against White Flame’s spearhead. The resulting boom was nothing a pair of weapons should have been able to make.

Neither was the shock wave that followed.

[3799] A zhang is a traditional unit of length, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Rumble!

The hard ground cracked like a spiderweb. My feet slid backward under the force, and everything in their path crumbled to dust.

“You dared wag that tongue at me when this is all you’ve got?”

Beyond our crossed weapons, his eyes flashed blood-red. His voice seethed with fury.

Killing intent I could almost touch. A terrifyingly vast surge of qi.

Strong.

I was surprised all over again. The Blood Lord had grown stronger, too, over the past year—long or short as that might seem.

At least half a move above me. No, a full move.

At Supreme Peak, a single move made an enormous difference.

But it wasn’t only his insight into the martial arts or the depth of his internal energy that surprised me.

Grnnnk.

My spearhead began to give way. Slowly—no, faster than that.

Beyond it was a red blade that flashed without any blood-red Force, and a muscular arm, bulging with veins as he squeezed out every ounce of strength.

That’s… not human strength.

I could tell by instinct. After spending years fighting monsters instead of humans, how could I not?

The physical power the Blood Lord was unleashing went far beyond human limits.

No. It was more than that.

One look at the skin exposed by the rips in his clothes told me enough to guess what he’d done over the past year.

“Unusual for a prosthetic arm.”

I put everything I had into holding back the force pressing against my spear and studied him. More precisely, I studied the arm swollen to an unnatural size and the marks that looked like seams.

The Blood Lord bared his teeth and growled at me.

“Everything is thanks to that person’s grace.”

The Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, had taken one of the Blood Lord’s arms during the Shaolin Bloodshed. The Blood Lord had fled.

He should have spent the rest of his life with one arm. Yet here he was with two, wielding this kind of strength. That could mean only one thing.

“Did you want to get stronger that badly? Enough to splice yourself together with a monster?”

“…!”

“Then again, forget about me. If you wanted revenge on the Sword Saint, you’d have had to tear something off and stick it on. Right?”

“…You.”

Had I struck a nerve? Or had I figured out the truth too easily?

The Blood Lord glared at me, eyes wide, and clenched his teeth.

“I look forward to seeing whether you can still run that mouth after you’re dead.”

At that moment—

Crack—KWA-AANG!

His arm swelled larger still, as thick as an old tree trunk. With a force that could only have come from a monster, he knocked my spearhead upward.

Clang!

Even my Strength stat, which had been in triple digits for a long time, couldn’t withstand that combination of raw power and internal energy. The shaft flew into the air.

My grip tore open. In an instant, I was empty-handed, and the Blood Lord’s Red Blade traced a dazzling arc toward me.

Whoosh! KWAANG!

Crude and brutal, the strike could have smashed anything in its path. Another followed it, cutting through the air like lightning.

His blade pursued me as my feet kept moving, the blood-red Force at its edge bending like a whip.

Whish—slice!

Every hair on my body stood on end. The Force skimmed past, slicing off a few strands of hair before slamming into the ground.

KWAANG! Rrrumble!

The earth shook like an earthquake, unable to withstand the tremendous force carried by the Force.

Dust billowed across dozens of zhang in every direction, but even that couldn’t block the Blood Lord’s view.

“This! This is all you’ve got!”

Whoosh!

The dust cloud split beneath a fierce sonic boom. I threw myself to the side on instinct, dodging the blood-red Force plunging down like an axe swung by some ancient giant.

Slice!

The ground split in two and opened a pitch-black maw.

I’d gotten out of the way in time, but the wind from the strike alone left me covered in blood. The Blood Lord smirked.

“Narye tagon. I heard you’d become the Divine Dragon while I was away, so I expected more. Instead, I find a lazy donkey rolling around on the ground.”

To martial artists—especially proud masters—Narye tagon was humiliation itself. Nobody who was anybody in the Murim wanted to be seen rolling through the dirt.

I didn’t care.

In low-level dungeons, I’d flattened myself against damp cave floors to avoid poison darts fired by kobolds. When an enemy got too close for my spear, I’d gone for the eyes or head-butted them without hesitation.

A character in a pirate manga that still hasn’t ended[3800] once said a wound on the back was a swordsman’s shame. I’ve never agreed with that.

“A wound on your back just fucking hurts. You have to be alive to feel ashamed.”

“What?”

I stopped moving.

The Blood Lord’s face seemed to ask what the hell I was going on about. I stood up, my body aching, and continued.

“I know it’s nonsense, so stop staring at me like that. You’re so cute I want to bite you to death.”

“You little—!”

“And what the fuck does it matter whether I’m a dragon or a donkey? You’re the one who tore the limbs off some monster nobody’s ever heard of and stuck them onto yourself.”

“…!”

A heavy Patriot missile of a fact[3801] was what hurt the most.

Grind.

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth so hard they seemed ready to break and started forward again.

Or tried to.

The killing intent around him thickened. Blood-red Force stirred around his blade. Then a tremendous explosion jolted his long-paralyzed reason back to life.

KWA-AANG!

The boom shook everything around us. It had come from behind him.

The Blood Lord had chased me for over a hundred zhang, raining attacks down on me. The two giants who’d filled the opening he left behind were none other than the Fire King and the Slaughter Saint.

Crack—boom!

[3800] This alludes to *One Piece*, a Japanese pirate manga in which a swordsman calls wounds on the back a swordsman’s shame.

[3801] The Korean phrasing combines “fact” with “Patriot,” the name of a missile system.

Flames erupted everywhere, and fountains of blood sprayed without pause.

Only then did the Blood Lord realize what was happening. He shot me a blood-red glare, but I just shrugged.

“Baiting you. Obvious as can be.”

“You—!”

“Oh, I can’t take all the credit. Someone said something pretty similar a little while ago.”

At that moment—

Whoooosh!

From the city wall, now much closer, a streak of light like a bolt of lightning pierced the pale dust cloud and plunged down.

KWA-A-AANG!

Chapter 1093

KWA-A-A-ANG!

The deafening boom left Jeok Cheongang's ears ringing. Then a tremor ran through the ground. He turned to look behind him and finally let out a sigh of relief.

The old hag's joined the fight.

Flashes of light were still streaking through the cloud of dust.

Once he saw that the Bow Saint was helping Jin Taekyung, part of him could finally relax. With her there, his Disciple would be safe.

At least for the brief time Jeok Cheongang needed to accomplish his goal.

I was worried sick… Maybe I didn't need to be.

In Jeok Cheongang's judgment, Jin Taekyung still wasn't a match for the Blood Lord. That was why he hadn't been able to hide his unease, even after hearing the Sound Transmission that had reached his ear moments ago.

"I'll draw out the Blood Lord and buy us time. You two should target their main force."

"What?"

"Don't worry. You know my life motto, right?"

Of course he did.

However thick or thin his life might be, Taekyung meant to survive and make it last.

But if everything in the world went according to one's wishes, every martial artist in the land would be a Supreme Peak master, and the common people would live long, healthy lives.

So Jeok Cheongang had firmly opposed the idea.

No—he'd meant to oppose it.

Before he could respond to that carefree answer, Jin Taekyung had charged out without hesitation to face the Blood Lord.

You idiot. Don't you know your life is worth protecting?

Yet despite the thought, a smile had found its way onto Jeok Cheongang's lips. It was plain enough that the Slaughter Saint, who was stirring up a bloodstorm not far away, couldn't hold back a comment.

"I know you adore your one and only Disciple, but are you really so eager to die that you—"

He stopped mid-sentence and caught his breath, twisting aside.

Whoosh-whoosh-whoosh!

Three streaks of sword light carved through the air, missing him by inches. At the same time, a flash glinted from the Slaughter Saint's sleeve as he spun in midair.

KLANG! Thud!

Two sparks—and the sickening sound of a blade piercing flesh.

Three black-robed men clad head to toe in pitch-black armor had charged at him like bolts of lightning. They faltered and stepped back.

Or rather, two of them did.

Thump.

The third fell like a rotting tree. A dagger the Slaughter Saint had just thrown was buried deep between the eyeholes of his helmet, which sat so low that his face was completely hidden.

“One down.”

The Slaughter Saint landed smoothly, as if nothing had happened. Jeok Cheongang, who had just swept away dozens of enemies with a flaming punch, shook his head.

“I don’t think so.”

“…What do you mean?”

“What do you think?”

Jeok Cheongang jerked his chin toward the fallen man.

“That.”

At that very moment—

Thrust.

The man they’d thought dead moved his arm and pulled the dagger from his helmet. Then he staggered to his feet and raised his sword.

As if he’d only been stung by a bee.

“…!”

The Slaughter Saint blinked in silence. Jeok Cheongang shook his head again, remembering the first time he’d seen one of those loathsome monsters.

“Didn’t that brat Taekyung tell you? There are damned things that openly defy the natural order set by Heaven.”

Only then did the Slaughter Saint realize who stood before them. He let out a low groan.

“…Black Ghosts.”

He’d already heard what had happened in Gansu. There were monsters that got back up no matter how many times they were killed, and every one of them had once been a fiend who dominated the Demonic Cult.

“I heard they were like the legendary living jiangshi. So it was true.”

“Worse bastards than living jiangshi. You can tell just by watching them move, can’t you?”

Jeok Cheongang stood beside the Slaughter Saint and gathered his internal energy once more. The Black Ghosts, now six in number, were closing in from all sides.

“How do we take them down?”

“I’ve heard there are only two ways. First, keep killing them until they die.”

Fwoosh.

White flames rolled over Jeok Cheongang’s hands. They lit the strangely dark space, revealing the Black Ghosts approaching with their eerie noises and the enemy forces packed tightly around them.

They also revealed other figures, hidden deep within that vast encirclement, controlling them.

“Second, cut off their heads and disable their arms and legs.”

And at that moment—

BOOM!

Jeok Cheongang thrust out both palms with all his might. Waves of flame scattered in every direction as he kicked off the ground and shot forward.

“Defend!”

—GRAAAAAH!

The shouts of humans and monsters mingled.

A path of fire opened through the enemies surrounding them. The Black Ghosts held their ground before Jeok Cheongang, but a sharp gust swept past their angled legs.

Whoosh. Slice!

The sword swinging toward Jeok Cheongang flew into the air. The Slaughter Saint had severed the arm of the first Black Ghost to charge.

“Go!”

The shout was brief, but its meaning was clear. Jeok Cheongang gave a small nod and advanced without slowing, clenching his fist.

Rrrrrk.

At the heart of the shimmering heat, white flame gathered around the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist, brought to the utmost limit of its power.

Even the monster standing nearly thirty feet tall and the Dark Heaven faithful packed into a defensive line widened their eyes at the heat.

And in that instant, when time itself seemed to stop—

“I am the—”

Jeok Cheongang’s fist shot forward, crushing the wind.

“Fire King!”

KWA-A-A-A-A!

Space warped. The ground sank.

Horrific heat melted the flesh and bones of everything in its path. A flash of white so brilliant it hardly seemed possible for flame blotted out his view.

Fwoosh—KRRRUMBLE!

The light faded as quickly as it had come. Jeok Cheongang saw what lay before him and finally released the breath he'd been holding.

Huu.

Heat poured between his trembling lips like flame from a weary fire dragon.

He had poured out all his strength, but the joy of accomplishing what he'd set out to do was greater than the exhaustion.

Sizzle. Szzzz.

The green ground was gone. All that remained was a hellscape spread between the scorched earth, black as a volcanic region, and a pale haze of steam.

Fsssh.

A hot wind blew from somewhere, and the bodies that had barely held their shape crumbled.

Monsters and humans alike. Even one unlucky Black Ghost who had stood directly in Jeok Cheongang's path.

With a single strike, hundreds of enemies had turned to ash and scattered. The same had happened beyond the thick veil of steam, which now spread dozens of yards in every direction.

At least, that was what Jeok Cheongang thought.

Then his senses caught something wrong.

Ssshhh.

An unseen current of qi crept through the ground and air. The moment he felt it, Jeok Cheongang realized what was amiss.

…This is.

Perhaps pouring out all his strength had left him too exhausted to notice at first.

Looking back, it had been strange from the start. How had such a dense, vast cloud of steam formed?

And why had the enemies beyond it shown no reaction at all?

Cold qi.

As the two words pierced his mind, Jeok Cheongang stamped down on the ground, which was slowly freezing over. He had already forgotten the horrifying heat from moments ago.

Crack.

A chill ran through his toes. At the same time, someone's face came to mind.

Jeok Cheongang looked at the steam with a sunken gaze and parted his lips.

"Anyone with the slightest bit of manners would greet an elder properly. You've got less respect than an eyelash, you little brat."

At that moment—

KRRRACK!

The steam blocking his way split apart.

No—it shattered in midair.

Beyond the bone-chilling cold stood an immense wall of ice. And with it, the person Jeok Cheongang had just thought of.

“You noticed. That’s just like you.”

At the Grand Sorceress’s reply, Jeok Cheongang spat out a wad of phlegm.

“Yeah. I knew it was you.”

That had been a strike delivered with all his strength—more than enough to turn even the sorcerers hidden among the countless enemies to ash in an instant.

Even a Supreme Peak master on his level would have found it nearly impossible to block the damage completely.

Unless they had the strange dark arts Jin Taekyung called Magic.

“So the brat was right. You managed to stay alive.”

“An old man who should’ve died and returned to the earth long ago is still walking around. Why should this be such a surprise?”

The Grand Sorceress continued with a sneer.

“At your age, you should be resting in a back room, watching your grandchildren play. Why come all this way to play with fire?”

“If my one and only Disciple is putting on a show for me, I can play with fire a hundred times over. A thousand, even.”

“Don’t push yourself too hard. Think of your age.”

“Don’t worry. Old as I am, I can still kill you.”

For an instant, the Grand Sorceress’s eyes darkened behind her veil. She heard the certainty in his words.

Sizzle.

The ice wall was still melting, little by little, unable to withstand the heat of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist. It bore out his claim.

…Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King. So his reputation isn’t empty.

Just as the Grand Sorceress thought this to herself and cautiously gathered her energy, Jeok Cheongang, who had been watching her and the three Black Ghosts guarding her with a sunken gaze, suddenly spoke.

“But today isn’t our only chance.”

In truth, he was just as pressed for time.

The Slaughter Saint was fighting desperately, surrounded by the six—no, now five—Black Ghosts. And his Disciple, who must not die, was fighting the Blood Lord.

Their agreed time was up. Though Jeok Cheongang had hoped for more, they had accomplished enough.

“Clear the way. Before I burn you all to ashes.”

Across the distance of dozens of yards, Jeok Cheongang’s reddish-hot gaze met the Grand Sorceress’s ice-cold one.

After a brief but long silence, the Grand Sorceress's quiet voice rang out.

"For that person's sake, I'll kill you. Even if it isn't today."

"Got any more bullshit to say?"

Jeok Cheongang gave a quiet laugh at the Grand Sorceress's silence, then swiftly turned around.

Chapter 1094

Time was always absolute.

But the way its passage felt was relative.

For Jin Taekyung, barely half a quarter-hour had passed in a desperate exchange that seemed as though it might go on forever.

Slice!

Scorching pain flared along his side. Taekyung wondered whether his body was growing sluggish as the wounds piled up, or whether the Blood Lord was getting faster.

Or both.

But his thoughts were nothing compared to what the Blood Lord was feeling.

What… is this guy?

The Blood Lord's eyes had blazed with rage, scattering streaks of crimson light. Now his gaze had sunk deep, and his eyes trembled faintly.

Three times.

Today marked his third encounter with Jin Taekyung.

The first time, he'd only watched from afar.

On the day the Jin Family of Taiyuan rose to become the preeminent clan of Shanxi Province, the young upstart who'd gone from the family's disgrace to a Hidden Dragon had struck him as interesting.

At their second meeting, a year later, he'd felt more than interest.

To be honest, he'd been surprised.

Chosen as the Fire King's Disciple, Jin Taekyung had grown almost unrecognizably strong. He'd become a young beast with even more ferocity in him.

So the Blood Lord had crushed him.

Thoroughly.

The Sword Saint's intervention had forced the Blood Lord to retreat in humiliation, but Taekyung himself had been easy to handle. The Fire King's teachings might have helped the young beast grow, yet the gulf between them remained as vast as heaven and earth.

Now another year had passed, and the Blood Lord faced an emotion beyond interest or surprise.

Astonishment.

…Why? Why won't you fall?

He knew what had happened, of course. Four Demon Lords and Demon Empresses had met their ends at the hands of a man who'd once been nothing more than a young upstart.

But he couldn't make himself understand it.

How had that happened? How could Taekyung stand against him without giving ground, when the Blood Lord's own might had advanced even further?

"You!"

Crimson light surged in his eyes once more. A larger, more powerful arc of blade Force shot toward Jin Taekyung.

Whoosh—slice!

Severed strands of hair fluttered through the air. Wind pressure tore the skin exposed by Taekyung's already-ragged clothes.

But that was all.

He slipped past the blade Force by barely a handspan and lunged forward without slowing.

Whoosh.

The distance between them vanished.

At the same time, a flash of light shot from far away, streaking over Taekyung's shoulder as he charged.

Another Force arrow. The Blood Lord was sick of them by now.

The Bow Saint…!

He gritted his teeth and brought the Red Blade down.

KWA-ANG!

Force clashed with Force.

Through the split-second opening, a palm strike wreathed in searing heat shot toward him.

Fwoosh!

The space around them wavered. Rising wisps of heat shimmered through his vision like a dream.

The Blood Lord didn't hesitate.

"How dare you!"

His shout rang out, charged with internal energy. He thrust out his free hand and seized the flames just before they reached him.

No—the palm behind them. Taekyung's palm.

KRRK!

Hand met hand. Crimson Force and flame collided and twisted together.

A terrible burning pain came with them, enough to make an ordinary person faint on the spot.

Sizzle.

The Bow Saint's intervention had delayed the Blood Lord's counterattack by half a beat. But even as his flesh burned, he didn't blink.

Instead, he growled at Taekyung, whose attack he had stopped. His voice was low, as though he were making a vow to himself.

"Did you think this would be enough to break me?"

He knew pain well.

He'd been in situations that should have killed him not just a few times, but dozens of times over. He had always risen again.

Through the blessing his master had bestowed on him. Through his own will.

"How dare a wretch like you—!"

Taekyung spoke quietly.

"You mean *wretches*. Plural."

"What?"

The question escaped the Blood Lord before he knew it.

Whoooosh!

The sound of powerful movements swept in from every direction.

As the thick dust cloud slowly dispersed, the indistinct figures within it came into view.

"Sorry I'm late, Benefactor."

Cheongpung's voice was unusually subdued. His eyes had turned deep purple, and qi from the Zaha Divine Technique enveloped his body.

Over his shoulder, two aged but clear voices rang out.

"Infinite Life Buddha.[3802] At last, I meet the unwelcome guest who came to our mountain."

"So you're that vicious fiend."

Cheongheoja and Perfected Being Hyeoncheon.

Cheongpung had appeared, followed by the Sect Leaders of Kunlun and Kongtong. The Blood Lord's brow twitched.

But he had also spotted someone who troubled him more.

The Bow Saint.

She stood silently with her great bow aimed at him, steady as stone. The Blood Lord couldn't afford to underestimate her, least of all now.

And they weren't the last to arrive.

"I had a dream once. Shakyamuni,[3803] or whatever the hell his name was, came to me and said something."

Step.

Footsteps reached the Blood Lord's ears a moment late. The master who had returned to his one and only Disciple continued, his voice seething.

"Hong Dao. He told me to burn the bastard who killed that damned monk until there wasn't a hair left of him."

[3802] "Infinite Life Buddha" is a Buddhist invocation referring to Amitabha, the Buddha of Infinite Life.

[3803] Shakyamuni is a name for the historical Buddha, Siddhartha Gautama.

“I figured it had to be nonsense, coming from you. But I’ll believe you this once. I had a similar idea myself, though not quite the same.”

“It’s true.”

“Fine, let’s say it is. Though I doubt Shakyamuni[3804] called anyone a bastard.”

The Slaughter Saint had appeared like a ghost, without the slightest warning, and joined the encirclement. The Blood Lord suddenly felt as though he stood amid a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords.

Including Jin Taekyung, he faced no fewer than seven Supreme Peak masters. Two of them were among the Three Saints; another stood foremost among the Ten Kings and was fully their equal.

It was no mere illusion.

“So this is what you were after?”

Crack.

A bone shifted between their locked hands.

The Blood Lord’s hand had charred so badly it seemed ready to melt, yet it forced back the flames through sheer, unbelievable recovery.

Sizzle. Slither.

He tightened his grip as the flesh burned and healed, burned and healed. A growling laugh escaped him.

“But look. Which of us is really surrounded?”

Jin Taekyung didn’t answer.

More precisely, he couldn’t. The Blood Lord’s internal energy poured endlessly through their joined hands, backed by strength no human should possess. Holding against it took everything Taekyung had.

Yet his steady gaze and sharpened senses still registered everything around him.

Another vast encirclement stretched across a radius of hundreds of zhang.[3805]

And at its front and center stood—

Black Ghosts.

Them.

Beings reborn from the pit of death. Death Knights cursed with something close to immortality.

In another world, they were called Death Knights. Taekyung could sense them clearly. More than ten stood like an iron wall, giving off suffocating demonic qi.

He could sense someone behind them, too.

The Grand Mage. No—the Grand Sorceress.

He’d expected as much. She wasn’t someone who would die that easily.

But expecting it did nothing to lessen the weight of the reality before him.

[3804] Shakyamuni is a name for the historical Buddha, Siddhartha Gautama.

[3805] A *zhang* is a traditional Chinese measure of length, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

At this rate, we'll all die together.

Perhaps the outcome would be even worse.

The Blood Lord and the Grand Sorceress had gained greater martial might and supernatural abilities since the Shaolin Bloodshed. Even if Taekyung and the others brought down every Black Ghost, there was no telling what those two might do.

He wasn't the only one torn at this crossroads.

Must I truly let this man live?

The Blood Lord asked the question in his heart, wishing he could put it to his master.

He knew how badly the Lord of Heaven wanted the accursed man before him. No one in the world deserved that title more than his master.

That was why, when he'd heard that four Demon Lords and Demon Empresses had died one after another, he'd mocked and cursed them instead.

Was it simply because they'd been weak?

Only in part.

He'd cursed them because, contrary to their master's orders, they had brought Jin Taekyung to the brink of death again and again.

But…

Now I understand why those bastards tried to kill you.

At last, he understood how they'd felt.

And yet he understood his master even less. Why did the Lord of Heaven want Jin Taekyung so badly—a man who thwarted Dark Heaven at every turn and was growing at a rate without precedent in history?

Why did he care more about Taekyung's safety than about the loyal servants who had always been ready to give their lives for him?

Lord of Heaven. My one and only master. Please tell this servant.

Tell him to cut down this bright-yellow sprout now.

No—Taekyung had already grown into a towering tree. Tell him to kill the man by any means necessary.

The Blood Lord pleaded more desperately than ever.

But that was all.

His voice would not reach his master. Nothing would change.

Grit.

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth and wrenched his hand away, putting all the fury surging through him into the motion.

KWA-ANG!

The boom drove Taekyung back ten steps. The Blood Lord spat out each word.

"There won't be a next time. I'll kill you. No matter what."

At that moment—

Bwoooooo!

A deep, resonant horn sounded in the distance, cutting straight through the taut tension.

Chapter 1095

Bwooo! Bwooooooo!

The deep, resonant sound of a horn carried across hundreds of jang[3806] and pierced Jin Taekyung's ears. He was suddenly sure he'd heard a similar sound before.

In a damp, pitch-dark land thousands of li[3807] away, at the very southern edge.

…No way.

A suspicion flashed through his mind. Eyes wide, he stared toward the sound.

And at last, he saw them.

Enormous creatures were charging through a thick cloud of dust in the distance. Even from this far away, their great swinging trunks were unmistakable.

Those are…

Elephants.

The largest, strongest creatures alive—not just among beasts, but among everything that lived on land or in rivers.

The people of the Central Plains called them *xiang*—elephants—and regarded them as mysterious animals. But to a few people, Jin Taekyung among them, they were fairly familiar.

For a brief time, they'd lived among people who shared their home with countless animals, trained and tamed them, and carved beautiful horns from elephants' tusks after they died.

"Nanman Beast Palace! The Nanman Beast Palace is here!"

On the nearby wall, Hyuk Mujin spotted the herd—hundreds of elephants by his rough estimate—and shouted, brimming with excitement.

"See that, you bastards?!"

Barely fifteen minutes ago, he'd stood on the wall swallowing nervously as he watched the fierce battle below. Not anymore.

"Come on, then! Let's have a proper fight! We're not so badly outnumbered now!"

He had good reason to be confident.

Soon after the enormous upheaval caused by the Southern Heaven Demon Empress's scheme had been brought under control, the Nanman Beast Palace had begun to move in earnest.

No—"move" hardly did it justice. It was a migration on a staggering scale.

They'd purged every diseased shoot that had grown within their ranks. Then they'd gone further, abandoning the homeland where their ancestors had lived since time immemorial.

[3806] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

[3807] This uses the Chinese *li*, approximately 500 meters or 0.311 miles.

Beast Miao King Yayul Cheok had been furious at Dark Heaven's scheme, which had drenched Nanman's jungles in blood. He'd grieved the death of his sworn brother Baeksang more than anyone. And he'd been deeply moved by the outsiders from the Central Plains who had saved his people from that terrible crisis.

United at last under the Beast Miao King, the Nanman Beast Palace swore to join the Murim Alliance and avenge their people. Then they left their bloodstained homeland.

Every last one of Nanman's tens of thousands of people went with them, along with the countless ferocious beasts they commanded.

And the fact that the Nanman Beast Palace's forces—who should have been in Sichuan—had appeared here meant something else, too.

"The Nanman Beast Palace, the Sichuan Tang Clan, Qingcheng, and Emei must have come together! You're all dead now!"

At Hyuk Mujin's shout, his fist clenched tight, the allies on the wall finally brightened. Until then, Dark Heaven's overwhelming forces had left them frozen stiff.

"Waaah!"

"Reinforcements! The reinforcements are here!"

"Yeah, you bastards! Let's have a proper fight!"

The Nanman Beast Palace's forces were said to be practically a small kingdom in their own right. And now they had three great sects with them, each representing the very heart of the martial world.

Those who had already resigned themselves to defeat and those who had been clinging to hope while forcing down their fear all cheered at the top of their lungs, as if they'd never felt either.

But amid the wave of joy sweeping the wall, one man gazed at the approaching dust cloud with eyes that had only grown darker.

The Nanman Beast Palace and the other three Sichuan factions? They couldn't possibly have left Sichuan unguarded.

Sitting on Taishan's unusually high shoulder, Namho slowly retraced his thoughts as he watched beyond the wall with a seasoned gaze.

The strength of the Nanman Beast Palace. The current state of Sichuan's Murim, already dealt a tremendous blow by the chain of events centered on the Western Heaven Demon Lord.

And the reason he'd thought they couldn't come.

Sichuan is one of the largest regions in the world. With front lines that extensive, the imperial army alone wouldn't be enough. So how could they…?

The world today was like a steep mountainside where even the boundary between Murim and the state had disappeared.

The snowball that was Dark Heaven had been rolling for half a century. By now, the enemy was a boulder weighing ten thousand geun,[3808] tumbling down the slope and about to crush the villages below.

No—the entire world.

That was why the Murim Alliance couldn't have found a way to rescue Qinghai under these circumstances.

Leave the slightest gap, and Dark Heaven would drive into it like a sharp awl.

Not merely piercing the surface. With the bizarre sorcery of a Moving Formation, they could reach somewhere deep inside.

And Sichuan's Murim was in worse shape than any other region of the Central Plains.

Worse than bad. Its situation could hardly have been more dire.

Enemies appearing like ghosts somewhere within Sichuan weren't the only threat it faced.

If they really have abandoned their base to save us, the enemies across Sichuan's border in Tibet could march straight through it and into the Central Plains…

The countless thoughts tangled together in Namho's mind, looping and colliding, vanished all at once.

A chill ran down his spine. As he froze, a low exclamation reached his ears.

"Would you look at all those elephants in one place. What a sight from up here. Glad I stayed."

Great Sir.

It was him.

Unlike Bow Saint, Cheongpung, and the other Supreme Peak masters, he had stubbornly held his position until now. He muttered in a carefree tone, like a spectator enjoying the view.

"Strange, though. I heard you can barely breathe just standing still in Nanman, but do all its people shave their heads like that?"

Namho, who had gone blank with shock, whipped around to face him.

"What… What on earth are you talking about?"

"What do you mean? I'm just saying what I see."

Great Sir tilted his head and pointed at the dust cloud slowly drawing nearer from hundreds of jang away.

From atop the wall, dozens of jang high, his Supreme Peak eyesight let him see what no one else could.

No.

[3808] A Korean *geun* is approximately 600 grams or 1.32 pounds; ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kilograms or 13,200 pounds.

Through the pale dust, so thick it seemed impossible to make out anything an inch ahead, thousands of people in red and yellow robes were advancing behind the elephants.

"Huh? Wait. Now that I look again…"

Great Sir stared hard at them, scratching his chin, then added:

"They look a bit like monks."

At that moment—

A shout burst from the lips of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion agent, who was nearing eighty. Even Namho startled himself with its volume.

"You goddamn bastard! That's the Potala Palace!"

At the same moment—

Bwooooooo!

To the deep, resonant sound of the horn, the Potala Palace's army charged like mad, hundreds of elephants leading the way.

There was an undeniable gap between the modern world of the twenty-first century and this one.

Some things were similar. Others were a little different.

And the land people here called Xizang, tens of thousands of li from the Central Plains and counted among the Outer Lands, fell closer to the latter as far as I understood it.

Xizang.

In Murim, I alone knew its other name: Tibet.

And there was another religious group living there within its own little world—the Potala Palace.

That was the identity of the enormous dust cloud that had suddenly appeared.

Bwooooo!

Hundreds of elephants trumpeted at once as they charged like mad.

Now that I could see them better, their tusks, which ought to have been long and beautiful, were blackened as if they'd been deep-fried somewhere. Their bloodshot eyes looked completely gone.

Those things… are elephants?

As they drew closer by the second, I felt it again.

They were different. On another level entirely.

They were nothing like the elephants I'd seen behind the bars at the zoo when I was a kid holding my mom's hand. Or the ones I'd seen in Nanman.

Their size, their madness, their ferocity. All of it.

Dumbo, the baby elephant I'd seen as a kid?

Give me a fucking break.

If the original author had used these lunatics as inspiration, the cartoon I'd watched would've been called *He's Just a Baby, but He's a Fucking Strong Elephant: Heavenly Demon's Reign*.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

The earth shook as if they really were using the Heavenly Demon's Reign.

No, that wasn't enough. Now the ground was splitting open.

Faced with real-life versions of the giant elephants from that movie about little folk destroying a ring, Cheongpung murmured, half dazed, "Whoa. I've never seen anything like that in my life…"

Neither have I, shit.

The words nearly escaped, but I managed to hold them back.

Why?

Simple.

Even without the Potala Palace rapidly closing the distance, Dark Heaven's forces still surrounded us on every side, packed tightly around us even now.

"They arrived sooner than expected. How fortunate."

The Blood Lord spoke with a relaxed smile.

"Of course, it's the worst possible luck for you."

I tightened my grip on the shaft of my spear instead of answering.

This was getting worse by the second.

We were already at a disadvantage, and now the Potala Palace from Tibet had joined Dark Heaven, too.

They never cared about Sichuan in the first place.

It wasn't as if I'd never considered this possibility. I'd just thought it unlikely.

So had most people.

We believed Dark Heaven had drawn in the Potala Palace, which had been quietly staying in Tibet, to block the front lines in Sichuan and stop any reinforcements from reaching Qinghai Province.

We were wrong.

What the Blood Lord—or rather, the Lord of Heaven behind him—wanted from what was happening in Qinghai wasn't some foothold from which to advance into the Central Plains.

Me. It was me.

With that realization, a huge rock seemed to press down on one corner of my chest.

So heavy it made me ache.

"Why?"

The question slipped out before I knew it.

The Blood Lord understood what I meant and answered readily.

“Do you think a fishing rod cast over a lake knows what its owner is thinking?”

“What?”

“I don’t know, either. I only do as my master commands. If he’d had them attack Sichuan, they might have opened a route into the Central Plains… but the Lord of Heaven had other ideas.”

“…!”

“Don’t worry. I’ll keep my promise to spare you today. But understand this: you’re already caught in a net. One you’ll never escape.”

Then the Blood Lord’s low Sound Transmission pierced my ears.

I’ll give you one day. If you sever your Sinews and Meridians and surrender of your own accord within that time, I’ll spare everyone but you.

He slowly raised a hand and smiled at me as I stood frozen.

I swear by the name of the Lord of Heaven, that person who is my one and only light and sky. This is my last mercy—and the only way to save your people.

That was the end of it.

As the encirclement parted at the Blood Lord’s gesture, the scornful smile on his lips stabbed into my chest.

Chapter 1096

Rumble, rumble, rumble.

The enormous, heavy iron gates of Xining slowly opened their mouths.

The Grand Sorceress watched the backs of their enemies as they passed through the encirclement, parted at the Blood Lord's signal, and headed for the gates. Then she spoke.

"Don't you think you let them go too easily?"

"Perhaps. But…"

The Blood Lord replied in a low voice, then nodded toward the towering city walls.

"If we'd fought them then and there, our losses would've been considerable, too."

The Grand Sorceress agreed, at least to a point.

Qinghai was a frontier among frontiers, a province that had stood prepared against foreign invasion since ancient times. Its walls, built from enormous blocks of dressed stone, were sturdier than anything in the Central Plains. Silver arrowheads already glinted along their tops.

And beyond Xining's slowly opening gates stood a forest of spears and blades.

"Cornered, they would've fought all the harder. They still have teeth to bite with."

Even a lowly rat would charge a cat if it thought its life was at stake. How much more fiercely would those people fight?

They had no fewer than seven Supreme Peak masters among them.

No—eight, counting the mysterious Great Sir who had never come down from the walls.

Then there were the Qinghai martial artists and imperial troops who had gathered in Xining early, with barely any losses. The Blood Lord's judgment wasn't wrong.

Of course, the Grand Sorceress thought there was another, more decisive reason for his choice.

He wasn't certain. He wasn't certain he could capture Jin Taekyung as that person wished—or, for that matter, that they could win outright.

But she kept the thought to herself. She could hardly stand the Blood Lord, yet they served the same master and pursued the same goal. There was no need to touch a nerve now.

At the same time, she could partly understand why he'd let Jin Taekyung and the other Supreme Peak masters leave without resistance.

"Well, it's a shame, but there's nothing to be done. I wasn't the one that person first entrusted with Qinghai."

"That's unusual. I never expected to hear you say that."

"I can separate business from personal feelings. I knew it would be a difficult battle, too."

There were levels even among Supreme Peak masters, and the seven they'd just surrounded were far from ordinary.

Cheongpung, the Huashan Divine Dragon, whose exploits had been somewhat overshadowed by Jin Taekyung's. Judging by innate martial talent alone, it wouldn't have been strange to call him the greatest of all time.

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon and Cheongheoja, leaders of the venerable Daoist lineages of Kongtong and Kunlun.

The Bow Saint and the Slaughter Saint, who needed no introduction, and the Fire King Jeok Cheongang, their equal.

And finally, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, who had proven through his every action that his very existence was a variable.

Looking at that overwhelming, dazzling lineup, even the Black Ghosts—nearly immortal as they were—seemed to fade into the background.

"If we'd fought, those things would have been wiped out, whether we survived or not."

The Grand Sorceress gestured toward the silent Black Ghosts.

"Though one has already melted away without leaving so much as its shape behind."

Jeok Cheongang's full-strength strike had been that powerful. It had even broken through part of the defensive magic she'd cast.

"And there'd be no question of it if the Bow Saint and Slaughter Saint joined in. Besides, there's something about Jin Taekyung that even I can't quite understand."

In Murim, where strength ruled above all, the logic of power was simple. The strong devoured the weak; the weak were trampled. That was how the world worked.

But from what the Grand Sorceress had seen, Jin Taekyung stood further outside that logic than anyone.

Even if he'd received help from those around him whenever he faced a life-or-death crisis, defeating four Demon Lords and a Demon Empress hadn't been mere luck.

She could understand why he was called the Chosen One.

"That must be it. There's something special about him, and that's why that person is so obsessed with him."

A faint note of wonder entered her voice. The Blood Lord's lips twisted.

Obsessed. Is that what it is?

He watched the gates slowly closing. More precisely, he watched Jin Taekyung's back disappear between them.

And he remembered what he'd said moments before.

Do you think a fishing rod cast over a lake knows what its owner is thinking?

He hadn’t said it only to Jin Taekyung. It was a self-mocking question directed at himself—and a plaintive complaint to the Lord of Heaven, who wasn’t there to hear it.

Why is that brat special to you? Why, exactly?

At that moment, the person the Blood Lord most wanted to kill wasn’t Mae Jonghak, who had once taken his arm, or Jeok Cheongang.

It was Jin Taekyung.

A greenhorn who had grown into a towering tree in barely two years. He was no longer a bright-yellow sprout the Blood Lord could crush underfoot. He had deep roots and thick branches now, yet his master still would not let his servants cut him down.

Lord of Heaven. What is it you truly want? This foolish servant cannot begin to guess.

A fishing rod.

Even if it broke against the strength of a great fish that had taken the bait, its owner could simply replace it.

The three words he’d spoken of his own accord, and the meaning they carried, weighed unusually heavily on the Blood Lord’s heart.

That was when it happened.

Bwooooo!

A horn sounded, long and deep. The Potala Palace’s army slowed to a halt some twenty-odd zhang[3809] away.

Of the hundreds of elephants standing like iron towers, thirteen of the largest and most lavishly adorned moved forward.

Thud. Thud.

The Blood Lord slowly raised his head as a vast shadow fell across his face. The elephants reached him, their heavy footfalls rumbling. A voice came down from atop their heads.

“It has been a long time, donor.[3810]”

Anyone from the Central Plains might have snorted at the halting Han speech. But the immense internal energy and authority behind the voice belonged to the grand master of a sect. It carried unmistakable anger, too.

“And yet…”

Thirteen figures dropped to the ground with a rush of displaced air.

At their center stood an old monk, slender and bony as a withered tree.

[3809] A *zhang* here is ten Korean *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Twenty-odd zhang is roughly 60–90 m (200–300 ft).

[3810] “Donor” is a Buddhist form of address for a layperson, not necessarily someone who has made a donation.

“If this humble monk has not mistaken what he sees, then I believe a convincing explanation is in order.”

The old monk ruled Tibet like a kingdom. He was the Palace Lord of the Potala Palace—or, as his people had called him by ancient custom, the Dalai Lama. He fixed his piercing gaze on the Blood Lord.

“Why did you let them go? I may be old, and my eyes may be failing, but even from a distance I could tell they were no ordinary people.”

Roused from his thoughts, the Blood Lord glanced at the gates, now firmly shut. Then he gave the Dalai Lama, who had brought a substantial force to join them, a warm smile.

“As expected of the Palace Lord. You saw them clearly.”

The Dalai Lama did not smile back, despite the Blood Lord’s unusually friendly manner.

What he’d just seen touched on one of the chief reasons the head of his fiercely insular sect had accepted Dark Heaven’s proposal decades ago and formed an alliance. It was also one of the main reasons he’d gathered the Potala Palace’s forces from across Tibet and brought them all the way to Qinghai.

“Then forgive this old monk for asking, just in case.”

When he continued, his voice was so cold that no trace of his halting speech remained.

“Were any of the enemies you just let go among those I’ve been searching for?”

At that moment, the Grand Sorceress’s lips moved behind her tightly woven silver-white veil.

I’m only saying this in case, but… don’t forget. Until we achieve our goal, the Potala Palace is a rather useful card to have.

Her warning reached the Blood Lord before he could answer. His lips twisted despite himself.

Our goal?

Ordinarily, he would have let the phrase pass. Now, for some reason, it struck him as absurd.

She and he were both fishing rods, after all. Someone could replace them whenever they pleased.

I’ve had only one goal from the beginning: to serve that person with body and soul, and help him rule as the master and father of all under heaven.

But why?

Why did he find himself thinking that his master, the great Lord of Heaven, wanted not the vast world, but one young man?

“Ha.”

A quiet laugh escaped him before he could stop it.

The Dalai Lama's gaze grew darker.

"I'm still waiting for an answer."

Amusement in his voice, the Blood Lord replied, "Surely you've already guessed."

"Does that mean…?"

"That's right. The Fire King Jeok Cheongang. And the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. The Fire Gate Clan's scions you've searched for so desperately were among them. Ah, come to think of it…"

He extended a finger toward the ground at the Dalai Lama's feet.

"I believe they were standing right where you are now. Only moments ago, of course."

"…!"

"…!"

The air around them shook with the aura pouring from the Dalai Lama and the Twelve Secret Monks, the Potala Palace's finest fighters.

"You let them go so easily? Even knowing how much I—how much we—hate the Fire Gate Clan?"

His voice was as dry as a desert of burning sand. The ruler of Tibet's vast martial world was furious.

The Fire Gate Clan.

A cursed name every Secret Monk of the Potala Palace knew and none could forget.

They were the ones who had driven the Potala Palace's transformation from a Buddhist sect known for its excessive belligerence into a theocratic state with formidable martial power.

"How dare you break your promise? What do you think you're doing?"

"Well, now…"

The Dalai Lama glared at him with a frost-sharp aura, speaking down to him as though it were the most natural thing in the world. The Blood Lord gave a short laugh.

"Don't worry. I remember perfectly well. That heartrending story from two hundred years ago, and the close bond behind our promise."

"What?"

The Dalai Lama's eyes widened at the offhand reply. The Blood Lord continued quietly.

"But unlike me, Palace Lord, you seem to have forgotten something."

"Forgotten? What are you talking about?"

"You know better than anyone how much help that person gave you in making the Potala Palace what it is today."

"That…"

The Dalai Lama bit his lip, unable to finish. The Blood Lord clicked his tongue.

"As I said, I'll keep my promise. If you play a substantial part in capturing Jin Taekyung, I'll put the Fire King in your custody and give you a generous reward besides."

The Dalai Lama was silent for a moment before speaking heavily.

"How can I believe you?"

"What, you don't trust me?"

"I trust that person. But you let them go right before my eyes, when we had the perfect opportunity."

A sneer touched the Blood Lord's lips. It wasn't the Dalai Lama's distrust that offended him. He found it laughable that the man truly believed what he'd said.

Even accounting for Dark Heaven's full support, the strength the Potala Palace had amassed was undeniable. The Dalai Lama was its greatest master; he could stand against any one of the Ten Kings besides Jeok Cheongang without being outmatched.

But…

That's as far as you go.

It wasn't a question of martial skill.

It was a question of the size of one's inner self. Of the person one was.

The Grand Sorceress had already understood what the Blood Lord intended when he let their enemies go, and had said nothing. The Dalai Lama could only lament the great fish he'd watched slip away.

"Do you still not understand?"

"What is it I'm supposed to understand…?"

"I wanted to make certain of everything. To leave them no opening to escape, however small."

The Dalai Lama was about to say something when he suddenly realized something and opened his eyes wide.

"Could it be…?"

The Blood Lord nodded without a word.

If his guess was right, it would happen today: the Yangtze River Channel League's hundreds of ships would finally enter the Yellow River tributary leading to Qinghai, where the Green Forest Alliance would meet them alongside the ten thousand followers who had joined them in advance.

"Another day, two at most. This battle will be over within that time."

Thirty thousand additional troops would cut through the swift current to reach Qinghai and close even the smallest gap.

They were the final key to a certain victory.

They were also why he'd given Jin Taekyung a day to think.

His promise?

He had never intended to keep it. In fact, he hoped Jin Taekyung would not be foolish enough to sever his own Sinews and Meridians.

Because only then—only if Jin Taekyung resolved to fight to the death—would the Blood Lord have grounds to kill him.

Lord of Heaven, forgive me. Even if this is not what you wish, I act only out of loyalty.

As if confessing his sins, the Blood Lord murmured to himself, then slowly parted his lips.

"So…"

He turned to the Dalai Lama, who was watching him with a face much brighter than before.

"Shut your mouth. Speak down to me again, and I'll rip that mouth apart."

"…!"

Watching the Dalai Lama freeze in place, the Blood Lord laughed wildly.

Once was enough to be treated like someone else's fishing rod.

Chapter 1097

The moment he saw the Blood Lord's savage smile, the Dalai Lama felt a chill race up his spine.

What in the world is this man?

He was different. Unmistakably different.

Something about the man before him stirred the primal fear every human being carried.

A darkness as deep as an abyss, enough to make even the ruler of vast Tibet shudder.

A predator.

He looked at the Dark Heaven followers who had surrounded him and the Twelve Secret Monks as if to enclose them.

"This humble monk… has been discourteous."

For a moment, he had forgotten what sort of man the Blood Lord was. And who stood behind him.

But when the Blood Lord bared the fangs he'd kept hidden, the Dalai Lama remembered the reality he'd let slip from his mind.

Who was weak, and who was strong.

If a conflict broke out now that neither side could take back, which of them would be devoured?

That was why the king of the theocratic state that ruled Tibet had no choice but to bow his head slowly.

"I swear, I had no intention of insulting someone the Lord of Heaven favors. It's only that I was troubled, and made a mistake…"

"A mistake."

The Blood Lord cut him off and ran his red tongue over his lips, like a beast savoring the sight of its prey.

Then he smiled at the Dalai Lama.

"I understand. Anyone can make a mistake now and then. Once."

The meaning in the Blood Lord's quiet final words was unmistakable.

Once. Just once.

He would not tolerate a second mistake.

The Blood Lord had gone back to addressing him respectfully as though nothing had happened. His attitude said the opposite. The Dalai Lama gritted his teeth and accepted it.

"Thank you for saying so."

"Come now, there's no need to be so formal. We're comrades working toward a great cause, aren't we?"

"…You're absolutely right."

Of course, the Dalai Lama knew how hollow those words were.

The balance of power had been settled decades ago, when he took the hand the Lord of Heaven had offered him. This was the generosity only the strong could afford—a carrot tossed his way after a crack of the whip.

But by now, the Dalai Lama and the Potala Palace had only one choice left.

They had to acknowledge it and accept it all.

Only then could they avenge the grudge passed down from their predecessors and survive in the new world Dark Heaven would one day rule.

"The Potala Palace will do everything it can to repay, in some small measure, the grace the Lord of Heaven has bestowed upon us. However…"

"However?"

The Blood Lord's eyebrow twitched. The Dalai Lama went on in a low, subdued voice.

"I trust you'll honor your promise."

The Blood Lord studied him as though he could see right through him, then clicked his tongue.

"So that's what you meant… Don't worry. The Fire Gate Clan's lineage will end right here in Xining."

"I don't doubt you, donor[3811], but couldn't they escape Xining and flee to the Central Plains before the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League seal off the rear completely?"

"Escape? Did you just say *escape*? The Fire King and Jin Taekyung, of all people?"

Before the Dalai Lama could answer, the Blood Lord laughed aloud and continued.

"Palace Lord, you hate the Fire Gate Clan more than anyone, yet you know nothing about them."

"If we're talking about a small handful of people—those two in particular—I'd say they have plenty of chances to get away. Even the Fire Gate Clan's fools, who can't tell up from down, might decide to live to fight another day when the odds are this bad."

He was right.

They weren't talking about the tens of thousands of troops huddled in Xining, or its hundreds of thousands of people. They were talking about a tiny handful.

And if those people were the Fire King Jeok Cheongang and the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung, they could break out through the rear right now and tear a hole in the encirclement.

But the Dalai Lama's concern only made the Blood Lord laugh harder.

"Impossible. Absolutely impossible."

[3811] Buddhist monks may address a layperson as "donor," referring to someone who gives alms.

“What makes you so sure?”

“Don’t you know? You just said it yourself.”

“What do you—”

The Dalai Lama’s question was cut short. The Blood Lord suddenly stopped laughing and spoke in a hoarse voice.

“Fucking idiots who can’t tell up from down. That’s the Fire Gate Clan.”

“…!”

“Master and Disciple alike, not one of them gives a damn about his own life. And with tens of thousands of allies and hundreds of thousands of civilians still here… well, that settles it.”

If those two had wanted to live to fight another day, they wouldn’t be in Xining now.

No. None of what they’d done up to this point would have happened.

Once they lost their temper, they’d charge straight in whether their opponent was the Demonic Cult or the Jade Emperor[3812] himself. And even with their lives at stake, if there was something they had to protect, they protected it.

Someone like the Blood Lord might mock their deeds as idiocy rather than chivalry.

But that was the Fire Gate Clan.

“I’ll say it one last time: they will never leave Xining. I’ll stake my life on it.”

More certain than ever, the Blood Lord recalled the young pup who had dared to face him a year ago in a blood-soaked valley on Mount Song, and how desperately he had fought.

He recalled the fire in the eyes of the young beast he’d faced again today—one he could no longer call a pup.

At last, he knew for certain what sort of person the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung was.

And he made up his mind.

Even if he had to defy the Lord of Heaven’s command, he would kill Jin Taekyung and eliminate the threat.

Even if someone inside smuggles him out through the rear, it won’t matter.

Farmers worried about their crops being washed away watched the sky closely. Everyone else noticed the storm clouds only when raindrops landed on their heads.

The peace that had lasted more than fifty years was long. And the storm clouds that had crept slowly toward them were now overhead.

Even as Dark Heaven’s concealed blade, planted deep within their ranks long ago, pierced their flesh, they had yet to notice it.

[3812] The Jade Emperor is a ruler of the heavens in Daoist tradition.

The moment I get the signal from inside, I'll strike and finish this in one go.

The Blood Lord smiled faintly and looked up.

One by one, raindrops fell from the dark sky, heralding a downpour unlike any before it.

An omen of the storm that would sweep away everything in Qinghai.

Tap. Plip.

As I felt the sudden raindrops wet the top of my head, I thought:

For a victory celebration, this is pretty damn soggy.

We'd fought a battle we hadn't planned on, but for such a short fight, we'd accomplished plenty.

By my estimate, we'd taken down hundreds of enemies. That included the Black Ghost Jeok Cheongang had reduced to ash with a full-powered strike.

Of course, that was only a fraction of them.

I kept that thought to myself and stared past the wall at the army blackening the land beyond it.

Hundreds fewer enemies. Thousands more.

For a moment, the balance of power had edged the tiniest bit closer to even. With the Potala Palace's arrival, it had tipped further against us than before. The weight of it pressed down on one corner of everyone's heart, mine included.

"Maybe… we've already missed our chance."

Watching the enemy build an ever tighter, more impregnable encirclement, Bow Saint continued in a heavy voice:

"Since we were already committed, we should've finished things before the Potala Palace arrived. We might've had a chance then."

At that one sentence, which put into words what everyone already felt, someone who'd been standing with his arms crossed in silence spoke up.

"Even so, if we use the cover of night to eliminate their entire leadership, we'll have a good chance."

If Hyuk Mujin had said that, I'd have hung him upside down and thrown him over the wall. Thankfully, it hadn't come to that.

The words had come from the assassin hailed as the greatest of all time.

The others looked at him hopefully, waiting for him to go on. I shook my head without hesitation.

"Absolutely not."

The Slaughter Saint asked:

"Why do you object?"

“Can I be honest?”

“When have you ever been anything else? Go on.”

“It’s simple. You’d go in there just to die like a dog.”

“…!”

The mood sank at once. The Slaughter Saint gave me a long, searching look.

“That goes beyond honesty. It’s almost a provocation.”

“I like joking around, and I’m good at provoking people. But I don’t do that to allies in the same boat. You already know that.”

“I learned something from facing them myself just now. If I go, there’s a chance.”

“How much of a chance?”

“One in ten.”

The Slaughter Saint answered as if the slim odds were no big deal, then looked at the rain, growing heavier by the moment.

“One in five, if the heavens lend a hand.”

“That’s all?”

“That’s *as much as* one in five. Considering what we’d gain if I succeeded, my life would be a bargain.”

He was right.

Even so, I could only smile bitterly.

“If we stood to gain anything at all, I wouldn’t have called it dying like a dog.”

“Now that they know I’m here, I expect them to prepare. They might even set every Black Ghost they have left to guard their leaders.”

“I know. I know you’ve considered the other possibilities, too.”

“Then why?”

“Because it’s simple.”

Naturally, I wasn’t the one who answered.

Jeok Cheongang had been silent all along. Now he spoke up and continued as everyone turned to look at him.

“Dark arts—no, Magic. When it comes to that damned stuff, even the greatest assassin of all time is as good as deaf and blind. Am I wrong?”

I nodded.

No—more precisely, before I could even nod, Jeok Cheongang grabbed my shoulder and made me move.

Before I could ask why, his low Sound Transmission slipped into my ear, and I had no choice but to fall silent.

—So, are you really not going to tell me until the very end?

Jeok Cheongang stared at me, his gaze sunk deep.

—What nonsense that bastard the Blood Lord was spouting at the last moment.

Chapter 1098

The human body holds more information than anyone might imagine.

And Supreme Peak masters, whose five senses have reached their limits, can read what lies behind the slightest change in another person's expression or movement.

Just like right now.

—So, you're planning to keep quiet until the very end?

A low Sound Transmission. Eyes so deep I couldn't guess what lay beneath them.

That alone was enough.

I hadn't managed to hide my momentary agitation, and the flicker in my eyes was practically a confession.

—What nonsense did that bastard the Blood Lord spout at the last moment?

As Jeok Cheongang's deep gaze seemed to see through everything, his Sound Transmission coming as if he were spitting out the words, I suddenly realized something.

Even if he hadn't been one of the world's foremost Supreme Peak masters, even if I hadn't let my agitation show, nothing would have changed.

Branches growing from the same root remain connected, however far apart they spread. My old master would have seen straight into his disciple's heart anyway.

So there was only one answer I could give.

—Maybe getting younger sharpened your hearing.

I'd be lying if I said I hadn't seen this coming at all.

Jeok Cheongang had once overheard the Roaring Fury Swordsman's Sound Transmission when the man came to the Jin Family of Taiyuan to threaten me. Then he'd beaten him to a pulp.

But comparing the Roaring Fury Swordsman to the Blood Lord was almost embarrassing.

I'd assumed that even Jeok Cheongang couldn't make out the Sound Transmission of someone who'd grown stronger still since the Shaolin Bloodshed. When he showed no sign of knowing anything after we returned to the city, I'd secretly felt relieved.

Looking back, though, I'd only had half the answer at best.

"Answer me. Now."

Jeok Cheongang spoke aloud.

Dozens of pairs of eyes turned toward me at once. I took a deep breath.

Then, at last, I told him the truth.

"You were right. The Blood Lord made me an offer."

"What offer?"

“He said he’d give me one day. I’m to leave the city alone, sever the sinews and meridians in all four of my limbs myself, and surrender.”

“…!”

“…!”

An invisible ripple shivered through the air.

Murmurs rose from the people who were only now grasping what had happened. Jeok Cheongang’s face went stiff as stone.

“And in exchange for your life, he promised to spare everyone else?”

Just as I’d expected.

I nodded with a bitter smile.

“Yes.”

“Why… didn’t you tell me from the start?”

“Because I was thinking it over. If this hadn’t happened, I’d still be thinking it over.”

“Thinking it over? That ridiculous load of crap?”

“The Blood Lord himself swore on the Lord of Heaven’s name. If he keeps his word, everyone’s safety is more than worth one life. Isn’t it?”

The Slaughter Saint frowned when I met his eyes and threw his own words back at him.

“Yes, perhaps. But you’re overlooking the most important thing.”

“What’s that?”

“Trust. Whether you can trust the person you’re making a deal with.”

The Slaughter Saint answered without hesitation, then continued:

“They’ll never keep their promise. When I spoke of taking a gamble earlier, I was betting on my own skill. You’re trying to strike a deal with someone who can’t be trusted in the first place.”

I bit my lip.

Honestly, I didn’t know.

No. Maybe some part of me already did.

Jeok Cheongang and the Slaughter Saint were right. The killing intent the Blood Lord had shown me before making his final offer had been all too real. So had his vow to kill me.

But there was another reason I couldn’t dismiss this absurd deal.

“Right now, the Lord of Heaven wants only one thing. Me.”

Looking back, the Lord of Heaven had always wanted me.

For a very long time.

Otherwise, he wouldn’t have left me alone all this time as I grew stronger by the day—so quickly that the saying “treat someone with new eyes” couldn’t keep up—even though I kept standing in the way of his path to ruling the world.

Why did the Lord of Heaven want me?

I didn't know.

But I thought I could make out one thing, however dimly.

"To him, I'm more important than anything else right now. Maybe…"

My voice trailed off. The hairs all over my body stood on end, and I let out the breath I'd been holding.

"Even more important than the world itself."

"…!"

"…!"

The truth had become too clear to hide. It was chillingly cold and dark.

Like the air around us, frozen in an instant.

And like the other reason I couldn't stop weighing his offer.

Whoooosh.

Rain hammered down all around us. I turned my head toward somewhere far to the east.

The sound filling my ears reminded me of water parting around a ship's prow.

They're coming.

I couldn't see them.

But I could feel them.

The final wave that would break the balance of this already-lopsided battlefield—and sweep away every last person in Xining.

Sometimes, there are nights like that.

The birds and insects and even the fish are asleep, and only the moon shines brightly overhead.

The fishermen of the Yangtze liked nights like those.

Whether they cast their nets or not, whether they were fishermen or not, on those nights everyone went down to the river. They'd bathe and set out in boats, filling their cups with cheap strong liquor and drinking their fill.

Grateful for the vast river that had given them so much, they'd row across the moon's reflection on the water, singing and enjoying a little time for themselves.

There had been a time like that.

There really had.

Splash!

Deep in the night, the pitch-black river split open.

Before the moon emerged from the clouds to see its own face reflected in the water, hundreds of prows covered the surface and surged ahead.

Fiercely. Endlessly.

It was like watching a city move. Like a wave that nothing could stop.

A mighty current that defied the order of heaven and dreamed of defying Heaven itself, one not even the Son of Heaven—the father and ruler of all under it—could stop.

And the countless flags streaming from the swollen sails had long since become objects of fear in their own right.

"What brings you here?"

Leaning against the prow, the old man had been looking silently up at the five characters painted on a flag in bold, imposing strokes: Yangtze River Channel League. Now he turned slowly and added, "Alone, and without sending word."

At the Seafaring King Pa Ryun's quiet voice, the subordinate who'd brought the unexpected visitor lowered his head, his face stiff.

"My apologies, Alliance Leader. It's just—"

"Enough."

Pa Ryun cut him off with a word, then addressed the visitor standing in the mast's shadow.

"I said anyone who neglected their duties before we reached our destination would be severely punished. Have you already forgotten?"

The visitor shook his head.

"No."

"Then did you think my disciple would be an exception?"

"No."

"Then?"

Thud.

With a heavy step, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song emerged from the shadows.

"I came to watch the moon with you, Master."

Watch the moon.

Pa Ryun found himself looking up at the cloud-filled sky. His voice stayed gruff.

"Under the League's rules, you'll receive thirty strokes with the oar on deck at dawn."

Mu Song faltered, then promptly asked, "Wasn't it twenty?"

"You disobeyed an order and spouted nonsense on top of it. You knew what you were getting into. Thirty."

"But—"

"Forty."

Mu Song fell silent. Pa Ryun turned to the subordinate, who was still standing there.

"You neglected your duty as well. Ten strokes."

"B-But, Alliance Leader—"

"Leave us. I'll let this matter go."

The Yangtze River Channel League's punishment was no ordinary beating.

A Peak master charged with enforcing discipline administered it with an oar of hard birchwood, drenched in water.

He didn't use internal energy, but ten strokes were enough to leave a man's backside raw and break several bones. The victim could expect to spend a couple of months in bed.

Yet Seafaring King Pa Ryun's strictness made no exceptions—not for his own disciple, nor for a subordinate who'd followed him for over thirty years.

In the end, the subordinate left without another word. By the time his presence had completely faded, Pa Ryun, still watching the river split around the ships, spoke abruptly.

"Perhaps I should make it fifty."

"What?"

"It's clear whose fault this is. You're at least ten years younger and in better shape, so you can take his ten strokes for him."

Mu Song stared at his master, then nodded with a bitter smile.

"I will. Fifty strokes should keep me from moving for three months. Maybe that would be for the best."

"There's a barb in your words."

"Then you heard me right."

Mu Song took a deep breath and dropped to his knees.

Thump.

"Please. Please reconsider your decision, just this once."

Before the sound had faded, he pressed his forehead to the deck.

"No matter how I look at it… this isn't right."

But even as his Disciple suddenly prostrated himself, the Master kept his eyes on the Yangtze.

"Not right, you say."

"I know it sounds absurd. I've been a bandit since I was a snot-nosed kid, too."

Pillaging had been Mu Song's trade.

Ever since he'd taken charge of Water Dragon Stronghold at thirty, he'd led a large family of followers, taking what belonged to others and sharing it with them.

But… he had never wanted this. Not once.

"The Yangtze is being stained with blood. And it'll keep happening. That wide, blue river we all love."

Mu Song's voice had begun to tremble. Pa Ryun suddenly spoke.

“Is that why you led the way in taking so many imperial troops prisoner in the last battle?”

“You knew…?”

“Do you think anything happens on the Yangtze without this old man knowing?”

“…!”

“It wasn’t only you. The Third Disciple and quite a few senior members pulled much the same trick. Or should I call it insubordination?”

“Master, it wasn’t insubordination. We only—”

“How dare you raise your voice before me?”

Pa Ryun turned and looked down at Mu Song, his gaze dark and steady.

“This old man ordered them killed, and you should have killed them. They were people it was all right to kill.”

“No. There was no need to kill them.”

Had they been strong, Mu Song might not have shown them mercy. He had himself and his followers to protect.

But the imperial troops he’d faced that day had been so weak that spilling their blood frightened him.

“That—that wasn’t a battle. It was a massacre.”

“Yes. That’s what this old man wanted.”

“…!”

“But in the end, only your Senior Brother and the Elders carried out my orders to the letter.”

Hiss.

Mu Song shuddered.

He had to stop.

Knowing his master’s anger, he ought to stop right now.

But he clenched his teeth and held out against the overwhelming aura bearing down on him.

Someone came to mind.

A man with martial arts strong as hell and a foul temper, who’d put Mu Song through no end of trouble. But he’d also shown Mu Song that even a river bandit like him could pursue chivalry.

Jin Taekyung.

“D-Do you still not understand?”

Struggling to breathe beneath that mighty aura, Mu Song forced the words out.

“Eldest Senior Brother—and those damned Elders, too. They weren’t following you.”

“What?”

“They’re loyal to someone else. Maybe they have been for a long time, M-Mas…”

Thump.

That was as far as he got.

As far as he could endure the aura of Pa Ryun, one of the Ten Kings.

His Disciple had lost consciousness before he could finish speaking. Pa Ryun looked down at him with a deep gaze, then turned back to the river and muttered.

To the tributary of the Yellow River, to be precise, its waters already beginning to turn the color of yellow earth.

“Yes. Better to stay as you are. Even if you stepped in now, nothing would change. Things would only rush toward their end.”

Just then, the moon peeked out between the clouds again, spilling its light over the earth.

At the same time, figures began gathering among the grasses not far from the riverbank.

Thousands of shadows. No, tens of thousands.

A voice, its laugh as faint as moonlight, spoke.

“It does seem a fine night for watching the moon after all.”

Hundreds of ships bearing the Yangtze River Channel League’s flags began preparing to welcome their new allies.

Chapter 1099

That night was unusually long.

Maybe it was the torrential rain, which showed no sign of letting up. Or maybe it was the dark clouds that still hadn't budged after several shichen.[3813]

The meeting dragged on beneath them, in an atmosphere so stifling that it didn't end until the hour of the Rabbit.[3814]

"Only one final battle remains. I ask every Great Hero here to rest well and carry out the duties entrusted to you."

I sounded far more formal than usual.

But not one of the leaders gathered there seemed uncomfortable with my new manner—or with a junior so far beneath them presiding over the meeting.

Anyone who might have stirred up trouble had already been replaced.

The eminent masters and generals of Qinghai Murim paid their respects with courtesy and resolve, then left to carry out their respective duties.

All except one old Daoist, who was still sipping from a cup of tea that had gone cold long ago.

"Nothing tastes worse than cold tea. What do you say? Shall this old man warm it up for you?"

Jeok Cheongang stopped on his way out to make the offer. The old Daoist shook his head.

"Cold tea has its own flavor, as does hot tea. Besides…"

His voice was as airy as drifting clouds. He turned to me with a smile.

"Why trouble Senior when I could ask this young Fellow Daoist here?"

Anyone else might have thought he was just playing with words. Cheongheoja—the old Daoist, and Sect Leader of the Kunlun Sect—could easily have warmed the tea himself with Samadhi True Fire.

But his answer was a roundabout refusal. He still had something to discuss with me alone.

Jeok Cheongang understood.

"Spouting airy nonsense. A Daoist through and through. Do as you please."

He gave a quiet snort and left. Once we were alone, Cheongheoja picked up the teapot.

"Would you care for a cup, Fellow Daoist?"

I didn't know what he wanted to say, but I had no reason to refuse.

"I'd be grateful."

"No need for gratitude."

[3813] A shichen is a traditional time unit lasting about two hours.

[3814] The hour of the Rabbit is the traditional time period from five to seven in the morning.

Cheongheoja smiled faintly as he poured. I took a polite sip, and a taste I couldn't quite describe, along with a bitter aroma, filled my mouth.

"Well? How is it?"

"Uh, cold."

"And?"

"Bitter. Really bitter."

"I often drink it cold. I should have warmed it to suit your taste."

"Mm. It's fine. Tea doesn't really suit my taste even when it's warm."

"Is that so? I put a good deal of effort into growing those tea leaves."

"…?"

Why the hell would he wait until now to tell me that?

Cheongheoja burst into hearty laughter at the look on my face.

"I'm joking. I do tend my own tea garden, but in a situation that urgent, why would I have packed tea leaves?"

"Oh."

I shook my head as I realized he'd caught me. Of course it made no sense to bring tea leaves when a hundred thousand enemies were bearing down on Mount Kunlun.

It wasn't as if he were Geum Jandi, honorary Sect Leader.[3815]

"You got me. I didn't know you were like this."

"Likewise."

"Pardon?"

Before I could ask what he meant, Cheongheoja smiled and went on.

"You have many sides to you, Fellow Daoist. When you uprooted the Qinghai City Lord and his faction in one stroke, you seemed like a Great General who could command the world. At other times, you seem an immature hero who leaves everything to his emotions. Yet in the end, you have the bearing of a grand master whom everyone can't help but follow."

Hmm.

What was I supposed to say to that?

Embarrassed by the sudden praise, I scratched my chin.

"You're too kind."

"No one would think so. At least, no one who has ever met *that person*."

That person.

I knew who he meant from the reverence in those two words. Cheongheoja spoke slowly.

[3815] Geum Jandi is the heroine of the Korean television series *Boys Over Flowers*. Her name literally means "golden grass."

“The Martial God. The greatest grand master of any age. Though his whereabouts have long been a mystery… I sensed something of him in you, Fellow Daoist.”

A thought occurred to me.

Maybe Cheongheoja’s words touched on a truth that was growing clearer in my mind.

Someone who had crossed between the modern world and Murim before me.

A Player who had roamed this world—a world that truly existed somewhere among the endless dimensions—as if it were a game.

Maybe that was why a murmur escaped me before I could stop it.

“…Maybe.”

“Hmm?”

“No, nothing. I just meant I’d like to become like him.”

It was a flimsy excuse even to me, but Cheongheoja didn’t seem to dwell on what I’d said. My voice had been barely audible, and unlike the Martial God, whose very existence was a mystery, my origins were known.

“I see. I believe you could.”

He nodded without a hint of suspicion, took another sip of tea, and added, “Unlike a certain Daoist who devoted his whole life to the task and never even reached the man’s feet.”

Cheongheoja had lived a life of great renown, both as the Kunlun Sect Leader and as a Daoist. Yet his self-deprecating voice held a regret I couldn’t place.

“The Martial God was a truly great man. He always concealed his appearance with a disguise technique and never properly revealed his true identity. Even so, everyone under heaven trusted and followed him.”

Cheongheoja wasn’t belittling his own accomplishments or martial arts by comparing them to the Martial God’s. He was talking about character, tolerance, and leadership.

And the conversation was drawing closer to the real reason he’d wanted to speak with me.

“Of course, even he wasn’t perfect. Dark Heaven’s schemes had taken root out of sight long ago.”

“Do you think this wouldn’t be happening if he were still here?”

“Of course. I lack the gift for reading the heavens that Master Hong Dao had before he passed away, but I’m certain Dark Heaven would have thought differently if the Martial God were still with us.”

Cheongheoja answered firmly, then sighed.

“But I could never become like him. The age of turmoil that drenched the world in blood ended, and peace came. Yet I couldn’t properly lead even my own sect, let alone all under heaven.”

I frowned before I could help it.

Don't tell me…

My instincts said this was no small matter. What he was about to tell me might be crucial to the coming battle.

Cheongheoja noticed the change in my expression and stroked his teacup with a bitter look.

"Until now… I didn't mind if the tea was cold as ice. I thought that if I could swallow it—if I could accept it that way—it would be enough."

Until now.

He had definitely said *until now*.

"I take it that's changed."

"It has. If the cold made this old man sick, that would be one thing. But I can't let hundreds of thousands of people suffer stomachaches, can I?"

"Hundreds of thousands…?"

At those words, I knew for certain.

There was a traitor inside Xining.

Dark Heaven had hidden a sword deep within our ranks—close to us.

Along with that realization, Cheongheoja's low voice pierced my ears.

Now I understood why he'd wanted to be alone with me. Why he looked so pained and sounded so bitter toward himself.

"It's my fault. I failed to teach that child properly."

"…!"

As I stared at him wide-eyed, the old Daoist with an unworthy Disciple silently raised his teacup.

By then, he had heated it with Samadhi True Fire.

Fwoosh.

Warmth spread through the air. Steam rose from the tea as Cheongheoja drank it slowly. Then he spoke, his voice heavier than I had ever heard it.

"I have a favor to ask."

At that moment—

Ding.

A System alert rang in my ears, and a translucent holographic window appeared before my eyes.

And then… a day passed.

The air in Xining was heavier and colder than ever.

Only a few days ago, the townspeople had smiled as they welcomed the newly arrived reinforcements. Now their faces were as dark as the sky overhead, as though they had some dim sense of the future before them.

Destruction and death.

The erasure of every living thing that would come at the end.

But who was it that said humans were creatures of hope? That they found their greatest strength when something was being taken from them, not when they sought to take from others?

And so they had not fallen into utter despair.

Here and now, with the last sliver of hope and yearning in their hearts, they looked toward the saviors who would light up the darkness settling all around them.

Splash. Splash.

Dozens of people marched in step, sending up splashes from rainwater that had risen to their calves.

The rain was still falling so hard it obscured their vision. Yet the countless townspeople filling the main road made way for them, scarcely daring to breathe.

Whoooosh.

Amid the clamor of the rain, the human tide slowly parted.

At the head of the procession, striding without hesitation through the countless people, was one man.

A young giant who had already carved his name into the minds of the people under heaven and the martial artists of Murim.

Jin Taekyung.

By now, everyone knew him.

Some might remember the young man as the Marquis of Shangshan; others might know him by his sobriquet, the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon.

But however they saw him, one fact would not change.

Today's battle, and the name Jin Taekyung, would enter the long record of history.

Even if his story ended in a hollow, miserable death.

"Fuck, did a hole open up in the sky or something?"

The young giant muttered the coarse curse almost too quietly to hear. Anyone who overheard him would have been shocked. He lifted his head.

The sky was dark.

Dark as fucking hell.

"Just the kind of weather I don't want to die in."

With a rueful snort, Jin Taekyung watched the shapes drawing closer through the distant rain.

A horrifyingly vast enemy army.

And at that moment—

Wooooong.

The opening shot of a battle that would decide the fate of Qinghai—perhaps of all under heaven—cut through the air.

Shhheeeek!

Hundreds of ice spikes.

Chapter 1100

Someone once said that people feel the greatest wonder and fear when they come face-to-face with the unknown.

When they encounter something they've never experienced before and see it for what it is, every emotion is pushed to its extreme.

Jin Taekyung wholeheartedly agreed.

He also agreed with something a certain philosopher had said: Humans are creatures of learning.

Whooosh!

Hundreds of ice spikes shot through the curtain of rain amid a tremendous surge of energy.

Yet even as the powerful, wide-ranging spell took shape, Jin Taekyung didn't flinch.

He'd expected it.

"Defend!"

The instant his shout, infused with deep reserves of internal energy, burst from between his lips—

Shhk! Fwssh!

Shields rose in a wave above the allies packed shoulder to shoulder along the high city wall. At the same time, brilliant beams of light shot up from all along it toward the hundreds of ice spikes.

Boom!

A thunderous crash. A flash of light.

The spikes shattered under the Sword Energy unleashed by the Peak masters, and fragments ricocheted toward the wall at high speed. But that was all.

Clang! Clang!

The massive rectangular shields, clad in steel on the outside, did their job.

If the spikes had retained their full force, things might have been different. But after that first blow had weakened them, the fragments couldn't break through the solid wall of shields.

"Everyone's safe!"

Excited reports came from all around.

But Jin Taekyung, who had anticipated the attack and prepared for it, didn't let his guard down.

They'd gotten the battle off to a good start. Holding off magic—something almost indistinguishable from a supernatural miracle in this world—had lifted their morale, too. That was no small gain.

But Jin Taekyung knew better than anyone that this was only the beginning.

So did the Grand Sorceress and the Blood Lord, watching from beyond the wall.

“Loose!”

At the forceful shout, the signalers on the wall waved their flags to pass along the command. Arrows that had gleamed from between the shields finally left their taut bowstrings.

Whooosh!

Thousands of arrows poured down, blackening a swath of the sky.

They were meant to pierce the throats of the enemies advancing below—the merciless invaders.

But the defenders’ desperate hopes came to nothing the moment the red lips hidden behind a veil in the distance moved.

“O invisible veil.”

There is a power in human speech that no one can explain.

A mage’s spoken command gives that power form.

Fwoom.

An invisible wall forced its way between spaces and split the air.

It was a powerful protective spell, one that steel arrowheads could never pierce.

Crack!

Thousands of arrowheads snapped or bounced away in an instant.

The people on the wall gasped at the impossible sight. But the woman responsible remained as calm as ever.

“They’ve prepared thoroughly enough. Their countermeasures aren’t bad, either.”

At the Grand Sorceress’s murmur, the Blood Lord spoke quietly.

“Of course. They have to fight with everything they’ve got.”

“Don’t you think we gave them more time than we needed to?”

“That’s a pointless thing to say. You know better than anyone this is the surest way. And besides…”

The Blood Lord looked calmly at the Grand Sorceress.

“You used that time to prepare, too.”

She gave a short laugh and nodded.

Her slender white fingers were already forming a hand seal. The movement looked perfectly gentle, but it held another spell of terrible destructive power.

Rumble.

The air began to tremble. Strange patterns etched beneath the Grand Sorceress’s feet flared with light in a multitude of colors.

There were dozens of them: Magic Formations she had prepared over the past two days for this battle.

“So, what do you want?” she asked.

The Blood Lord briefly considered the question.

What do I want?

Jin Taekyung's death, of course.

But he had to swallow the words welling up in his throat.

That stupid bitch would never defy *that person's* will, and even he had no idea how she would react if she learned what he was thinking.

So he forced himself to answer calmly.

"The wall. Aim for the wall. Hit it hard enough to bring it down in one blow."

The Dalai Lama, who had listened to their exchange in silence like a docile lamb, suddenly spoke.

"If the wall falls before the rear is completely sealed off, won't the enemies give up resisting and flee?"

His suggestion sounded reasonable at first, but neither the Blood Lord nor the Grand Sorceress paid it the slightest mind.

Bringing the wall down wasn't their only reason for targeting it first.

Fwoosh.

The Grand Sorceress slowly extended a hand. High overhead, the rain pouring endlessly from the sky stopped at her will, then began to gather.

By the time it had formed dozens of enormous spheres of water, she spoke again.

"Fly."

At her quiet command, the spheres hurtled toward the wall. Each carried the weight and force of ten thousand geun[3816], surging forward with a speed and momentum that seemed to brook no interference.

ROOOAR!

That was when the archers, who had been firing without pause at the approaching enemy, stared with their mouths open. The shield bearers guarding the front lowered their shields without realizing it.

At last, *they* stepped forward.

Whoosh!

Dazzling flashes cut through the air.

Some were as hot as lava. Others were stealthy enough to send a chill down the back of the neck. Still others were as swift as lightning.

By the time the martial artists and imperial troops on the wall sensed them, it was over.

Fwoosh! Boom!

The enormous spheres of water evaporated, were sliced apart, and burst.

[3816] A Korean geun is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is about 6,000 kg (13,000 lb).

Spheres that had looked capable of flattening a mountain, let alone the city wall. Terrifying calamities that had seemed as impossible for a human to stop as a natural disaster.

"…!"

"…!"

Those who'd instinctively sensed their imminent deaths opened their eyes wide in unison.

At the same time, they remembered something they had momentarily forgotten.

Those terrifying dark arts called magic weren't the only thing beyond human power.

"They're coming in hard from the start."

Across the world, only ten great martial artists had earned the right to a king's throne. Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, held the highest seat among them, shoulder to shoulder with the stars in the heavens.

He spat out some phlegm and grinned.

"How'd they know this old man likes that sort of thing?"

His voice rumbled like a beast's growl, and warmth rose in the people's chests.

The tiny spark of hope, beginning to stir again, blazed brighter still when the giants who appeared next came into view.

"They're trying to wear down our key fighters."

He looked more like a boy than a young man. But everyone knew now that the boy, who still looked as if he hadn't even lost all his baby fuzz, was the Slaughter Saint, once revered by all.

They knew, too, that another man whose legend could rival his stood among them.

"Obvious, but effective."

The voice was clearer than raindrops. At odds with it, a rough finger drew back a bowstring.

Whoosh!

A beam of light shot forth.

And then, destruction.

Crack!

The beam shattered the invisible protective veil over the enemy forces in an instant, then exploded with a thunderous roar.

It tore through the ground and pierced the enemies beneath it.

BOOM!

The ground shook. The blast swallowed their screams.

Neither the hulking monsters moving like little hills nor the Dark Heaven followers advancing behind them under their cover could withstand that One Strike.

The name Bow Saint was no empty boast.

We can do this.

A glimmer of hope flashed through the minds of the people on the wall, and they trembled with emotion.

They saw the radiance of those who had not lost their light, even in a world this dark.

They saw the other Supreme Peak masters stepping forward to block the magic that kept crashing toward the wall, and Jin Taekyung, who remained completely unfazed even in this dire situation.

They were moved. They shuddered.

They stood shoulder to shoulder with living legends, and those legends were giving everything they had to save them.

Thud. Thud-thud. Thud-thud-thud!

A massive rumble rippled outward like a wave.

As if they had all agreed to it, they stamped their feet. They slammed down their shields, beat their spear shafts, and struck their swords and sabers together.

Even as a fierce rain of fire poured down. Even as lightning flashed and ice bearing a terrible chill came flying at them. Even as the rain that should have soaked their heads turned to arrows.

They did not yield.

No—they never doubted that, whatever end awaited them here today, they too would become part of the legend.

And as the little sparks in their hearts grew into a great torch—

Rumble!

The hulking monsters, who'd steadily advanced despite the relentless rain of arrows and other attacks, charged toward the wall with a roar like an earthquake.

—GRAAAAH!

Their roar made the defenders' hair stand on end.

At the same instant, one of the monsters launched its body forward with strength and speed far beyond human limits and slammed into the wall with all its might.

RUMBLE!

Chapter 1101

For ages, people had called the lands north and south of the Yellow River the Central Plains and considered them the heart of the world.

The birthplace of the earliest civilization. Fertile land, abundant resources, and the staggering productivity they made possible.

With advantages like those, people were bound to flock there from every direction.

The problem was that among them were foreign peoples from distant borderlands, who often wanted to “borrow” the Central Plains’ gold and silver treasures.

By their own methods: plunder or occupation.

Naturally, the people of the Central Plains weren’t too fond of that.

So they built the Great Wall, stretching a full ten thousand li.[3817] They strengthened the armies stationed along the borders, raised impregnable fortresses and walled cities throughout the land, and kept reinforcing them generation after generation.

All the more so in Xining, the capital of Qinghai—the farthest of the borderlands, practically the continent’s GOP.[3818]

But the rulers who gave those orders, and the craftsmen and laborers who sweated to carry them out, could never have dreamed there were madmen who would hurl themselves bodily against walls built of solid stone, stacked layer upon layer and sealed tight with lime.

Or that those madmen would be enormous monsters, hideous and monstrously strong.

Rumble, rumble!

The ground—or rather, the city—shook.

Several thousand monsters battered the wall with their bare bodies or with huge logs and clubs they’d gotten from who knew where. The sight alone was enough to freeze the blood.

It doused the defenders’ fighting spirit just as it had begun to blaze.

“Hah…!”

“Don’t break formation! Hold your positions!”

Choked breaths escaped here and there amid a storm of shouted commands.

And this wasn’t happening only at the West Gate, where I was stationed.

[3817] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi). Ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

[3818] GOP stands for General Outpost, a term for a South Korean military position near the Demilitarized Zone.

The North Gate and South Gate were the same. So was the East Gate, though the assault there was comparatively light.

Countless enemies had encircled Xining for dozens of li.[3819] Now, with those stubbornly resilient monsters in front, they were beginning their siege in earnest.

“Archers, ready!”

“Loose! Loose!”

Shhk, thud-thud!

Our response was swift, too.

A dense rain of arrows fell at nearly direct-fire angles, holding back the Dark Heaven followers, while we brought out the countermeasure we’d prepared for the monsters.

“Is it ready?”

One of the commanders answered my quiet question. Sweat had already soaked the inside of his helmet.

“Everything’s prepared, just as the Marquis of Shangshan ordered.”

Then there was no need to hesitate any longer.

I turned to the tense commander and the imperial troops standing by.

“Pour it all out. Give them the works.”

The moment I gave the order—

Groan.

Signal flags swung vigorously. With a heavy metallic groan, the great iron cauldrons set along the wall tipped and disgorged their contents.

Thick, black, boiling oil.

Splash! Ssssss!

—GRAAAAH!

Acrid smoke mingled with the smell of burning, and the monsters’ screams rose over it all.

But I knew better than anyone that oil alone wouldn’t be enough to destroy creatures that were practically undead monsters already.

And with the sorcerers controlling them still nowhere to be seen, this was the right moment for me to act.

Fwoosh.

I drew a deep breath, and the fire dragon coiled deep inside me awoke.

It had left its longtime home in my Lower Dantian. Now the enormous flame had made a nest atop the peak of my Middle Dantian, a peak that touched the heavens. It stirred and flowed into every part of my body.

Endlessly. Fiercely.

[3819] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi). Ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,100 mi).

And at the same time, as swiftly as a ray of light.

Whoosh.

The moment I stepped forward, a spine-chilling sensation of weightlessness swept through me.

Before I knew it, everything lay beneath my feet.

The city wall, rising a dozen or so jang[3820] like a barrier at the edge of the world. The monsters and fanatics blackening the ground below.

Only one thing was level with my eyes.

A spear, wreathed in the flames of dark blue Force.

Grind.

Every muscle in my body drew taut as a bowstring. My senses, sharper than ever, focused at my fingertips.

I sought the most destructive, most perfect path for the spear to take as it cut slowly through the air and plunged down.

Now.

With that thought, I sent White Flame hurtling toward the distant ground.

Whoosh!

A flash of light. Through the air warped by searing heat, a streak of dark blue flame slipped among the enemies near the wall.

Then came a roar like the sky splitting open.

BOOM!

A vast pillar of fire surged up along the wall, defying the heavy rain pouring down without end.

Beneath it lay ground soaked with the oil we'd poured out so freely—and the enemies' flesh and bones.

"Ghk, aaagh!"

"Keugh…!"

For better or worse, enemies who had barely escaped death were engulfed in flames and let out terrible screams.

Hundreds of them, at a rough count.

Maybe more.

But before the enormous roar that had shaken heaven and earth could even fade, my body was already dropping over their heads.

Bang! Bang! Ba-bang!

The air burst beneath my feet with each successive step.

The ground that had seemed impossibly far away rushed toward me. I reached into the empty air, where only wind and rain whipped past.

[3820] A jang is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Inventory open. Summon.

Ding.

A System notification sounded, and something solid filled my empty hand. The enemies who had rushed toward the spot where I was descending from the sky stared wide-eyed.

“What the—”

Shhk!

One stroke, two halves.

The enemies proved those four words with their lives as their bodies split left and right.

A fountain of blood, vivid red even beneath the dark sky, spurted up. Madness glinted in the eyes of the enemies, already losing their focus.

“Heaven above and earth below, all demons bow!”

“Attack!”

Shh-shh-shhk!

A wind of blades swept in, colder than the rain.

The enemies had me surrounded on all sides, from every direction, and rushed in without regard for their lives.

Like moths drawn helplessly toward a flame.

Shhk!

Sharp Sword Energy slashed in from all sides.

Every streak was blood-red and looked dangerously unstable, as though its wielder had reached into a realm he had no business touching. Yet their power and speed rivaled a Peak master’s.

I still remembered seeing the same thing before.

Temporary Strength Pills.

A person’s final flame, fed with their own life.

I knew how tremendous the pills’ effects were, even if they lasted only a short time. Their danger matched their power.

I also knew that their hastily stacked kindling couldn’t match the heat of the furnace I’d built by surviving countless brushes with death.

Thump!

To conserve my strength, I hadn’t put so much as a trace of internal energy into the blow.

It was enough.

My body had already surpassed human limits by several steps. My senses, honed in the face of death, made it possible.

Grrk.

The Dark Heaven follower clutched at his throat, split open in an instant. By then, I'd already passed him and leaped toward the others.

Whoosh!

Half a step left.

Three streaks of Sword Energy missed me by a hair and tangled in midair. The rough broad-bladed saber that had been rusting in Xining's armory left my hand.

Wham!

Without an ounce of internal energy behind it, the blade spun with sheer, terrifying force and cut through three necks.

No—it smashed through them.

At the same time, a command rang out in my mind, and new blades appeared in both hands.

A straight sword in my left. A narrow-bladed sword in my right.

They were unfamiliar. Yet somehow, impossibly familiar.

Shreeeek! Thud-thud!

Just the right amount of strength and speed, guided by movements that followed the flow of battle.

I fell into a Trance and swept through the enemies beneath the wall. Each swing of my sword and saber brought blood and screams. With every step, corpses spread beneath my feet like a carpet.

Come.

I spared even the single breath I might have let out without thinking.

With that single thought, I cut down the enemies surging at me from every direction. I cut and kept cutting.

I dodged a thrusting sword and pierced its wielder's heart with the narrow-bladed sword. With nothing but a straight sword gone red with rust, I controlled the blades of five swords imbued with Sword Energy.

Clang-clang-clang!

I pressed against the flats of their blades and twisted. That was enough to knock the swords into one another in a tangle and cut off their wielders' breath.

Strength when strength was needed. Softness when softness was needed.

When the narrow-bladed sword broke, I summoned an axe from the nearly infinite storeroom of my Inventory. With the broken straight sword, I wielded a blade technique infused with the principles of the Flame Divine Palm.

Even I couldn't understand it. In that moment, I was free of every restriction and limit.

And suddenly, I understood.

So that's what he meant.

Jeok Cheongang had once told me that when one's understanding of martial arts reached a certain realm, every living, moving thing became a martial art.

Even a weak, bending reed would be no different from a Divine Sword.

Of course, I hadn't reached that realm. But at last, I felt I could faintly grasp what he'd meant.

Shhk!

With the sensation of death running through my fingertips, I started to turn toward another enemy—then blinked.

There was no one. Everything was quiet.

The Dark Heaven followers who had taken Temporary Strength Pills. The enormous monsters that could no longer be called human.

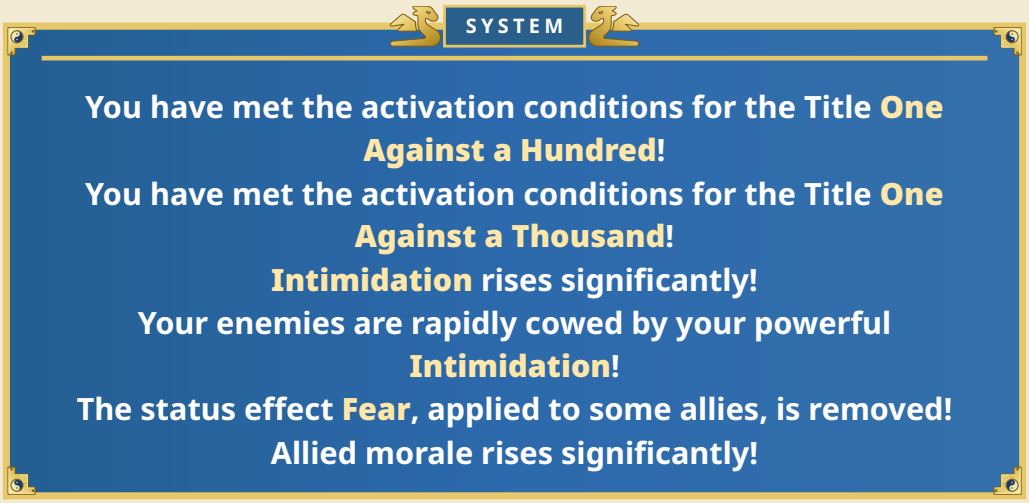
Beneath the western wall, I was the only one left standing on two feet.

The blood-soaked scene before me meant one thing.

I had wiped out the enemy vanguard, at least a thousand strong.

All by myself.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



System notifications poured into my ears like a dam breaking. A tremendous cheer erupted from atop the wall.

Then—

BWOOOOO!

A horn sounded with a deep note that made me shudder. At its call, Dark Heaven's main force—some hundred thousand strong—began advancing toward the city walls.

And I realized what their movement meant.

"…!"

The monsters.

No—the giants.

Each stood well over a jang[3821] tall. Their corpses had already piled halfway up the wall.

[3821] A jang is a traditional length of ten ja, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 1102

Looking back over the whole of human history, sieges had always overwhelmingly favored the defenders.

If you wanted to take what belonged to someone else, you had to pay a fitting price.

An attacking force needed at least three times as many soldiers to capture an ordinary castle or fortress. And even with more than that, the chances of losing a siege were still considerable.

To some people, though, that was nothing but old, rusted history.

"'Impregnable' is just nonsense left behind by weak losers."

Rumble.

A vast rumble rolled over the Blood Lord's low voice.

At that moment, Dark Heaven's enormous army advanced toward the city wall like a single wave, turning the once-green expanse of land pitch-black.

They would use the corpses of humans and monsters as footholds to scale that towering wall.

They would write a new history of their own.

The vanguard was annihilated faster than I expected…but it doesn't matter. As long as we take Xining and cut that bastard's throat.

Jin Taekyung, defending the West Gate, hadn't been the only one to stop the vanguard.

The Bow Saint and Slaughter Saint had defended the South Gate and East Gate, respectively, while the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, held the area around the North Gate. Four other Supreme Peak masters supported them from behind.

Yet even after thousands in the vanguard had vanished in reckless charges against the walls on all four sides, the Blood Lord remained unmoved.

This much loss is nothing if it means achieving my goal.

The monsters had been prepared for a moment just like this.

They would have been powerful assets in a battle on open ground, but the best use for an expendable asset depended on the situation.

Though he had lost nearly half the monsters, the Blood Lord was certain he'd made the right choice.

If he had sent ordinary followers—mere humans—out in front, they would have lost not thousands but tens of thousands before they could begin a proper siege like this.

"What about the mages? Are they all in their assigned positions?"

The Grand Sorceress nodded at the Blood Lord's sudden question.

The hundred or so mages under her command were a core part of their forces, no different from a modern magic corps. They also had a vital role in this battle.

Under the ironclad protection of their allies, they were to keep the Supreme Peak masters off balance.

“Keep up the pressure. Make sure they have to spend their strength without a moment’s rest.”

Even with an overwhelming advantage, the Blood Lord wasn’t letting his guard down.

The four Demon Lords and the Demon Empress who had already met their ends had taught him a valuable lesson. And even without them, the defenders were an impressive lot.

No fewer than eight Supreme Peak masters.

One of them, the fool they called Great Sir, seemed so far gone that it was hard to imagine he could even function. But so many powerful fighters had rarely gathered in one place, even during the countless battles of the Great Faction War.

No—for that matter, the total number of troops assembled on this battlefield might be unprecedented in the history of Murim.

That was why the Blood Lord couldn’t allow even the slightest variable.

Especially not the one person who had created more variables than anyone else, time and again.

Jin Taekyung.

His gaze grew deep and still.

In the distance, he saw the young man standing in the path of his charging followers, whose cries shook heaven and earth.

He saw the fountains of blood erupting ceaselessly around him, too.

Fwoosh!

With every flash, another life flickered out.

His movements had reached an astonishing realm: simple, swift, and utterly overwhelming.

And yet—

Nothing lasts forever.

Jin Taekyung was undoubtedly strong.

He might even be growing stronger, little by little, at this very moment.

But everything had its limits.

In the end, he’ll grow tired. Jin Taekyung, the Fire King, and all the other old men.

Unless the Blood Lord gave the order, the wheels of this enormous war of attrition, turning on the back of overwhelming numbers and strength, would never stop.

Not until the eight Supreme Peak masters—the defenders’ heads and hearts—were exhausted.

The Blood Lord sensed that moment was drawing near.

And he knew what he needed to prepare to cut Jin Taekyung's throat.

"From now on, the West Gate is mine alone."

The Grand Sorceress understood the meaning behind his sudden announcement.

"For some reason, that sounds like you're ordering me to leave. Am I imagining things?"

"That's exactly what it is. Your imagination."

"Then why should I leave the West Gate?"

"Do you need a reason? I'm the commander in chief."

"I know. I just have my doubts."

"Doubts? What exactly are you trying to say?"

"Well. For instance…"

The Grand Sorceress let her voice trail off. She looked from Jin Taekyung, fighting desperately to defend the western wall, to the Blood Lord.

"I worry that someone who's always claimed to be *that person's* most devoted servant might be a little too devoted—even to the point of defying his master's wishes."

It was as if she'd seen straight through him.

But the Blood Lord showed not the slightest hint of agitation.

He had considered that the Grand Sorceress might suspect his intentions from the moment he decided to kill Jin Taekyung.

"That's beyond imagining things. You're going senile. Do I look like an idiot who'd commit such an act of disloyalty?"

His reply was calm, without a trace of hesitation. The Grand Sorceress studied him for a moment, then shrugged.

"True. Disloyal is the last thing I'd call you. Though your loyalty has made you look like an idiot now and then."

In the past, the Blood Lord would have bared his teeth and snarled at that. But his mind was colder than ever.

"So, what's your answer?"

"Fine. Where should I go?"

"Take the South Gate."

"The South Gate? The Bow Saint?"

"I'll assign you three Black Ghosts. No, four. With that much force, even the Bow Saint won't have many options."

What the Blood Lord said was true, but the Grand Sorceress frowned.

"Black Ghosts? Four of them?"

Nine Black Ghosts had yet to enter the battle.

Even after one had been lost to the Fire King and Slaughter Saint's surprise attack, assigning her four was hard to understand. They retained all the martial prowess they'd possessed in life and could recover from almost any wound.

And it wasn't merely a question of her safety. Sending four to the South Gate would leave a gap in the forces available to break through the walls on all sides when the time came.

But her doubts vanished at the Blood Lord's next words.

"Don't hold back. You and the mages—press them hard. Once the Black Ghosts appear as well, the enemy will commit more of their strength to the South Gate."

The Grand Sorceress finally understood and let out a quiet laugh.

"So I'm bait to draw in the Fire King or the Slaughter Saint?"

"Half right, half wrong."

"What?"

"The Fire King won't go to the South Gate. He'll be busy greeting an unexpected guest."

The Blood Lord answered without hesitation. He turned his cold gaze toward the Dalai Lama, who had been watching the northern wall all this time.

"Isn't that right, Palace Lord?"

"…!"

The Dalai Lama's eyes trembled.

The moment of revenge he had waited so long for had finally arrived. Slowly, he parted his lips.

"What should this humble monk do?"

"Show that old man, the Fire King, the resentment and strength the Potala Palace has built through long years of endurance."

"I have waited my whole life for this moment alone."

The Dalai Lama pressed his palms together with heartfelt sincerity, then leaped atop a massive elephant.

"Come. The time has come to avenge our ancestors."

His quiet voice, infused with internal energy, carried on without end.

The Twelve Secret Monks, including two Supreme Peak masters, and the Potala Palace's ten thousand monks answered with a roar loud enough to make their ears ring.

Bwooooo!

A horn sounded, shaking the battlefield.

The great army of Tibet's Murim, now a single religious state, charged through the torrential rain toward the North Gate.

To trample the descendants of the Fire Gate Clan, sworn enemies with whom they could never share the same sky.

To offer the head of Jeok Cheongang, the current Sect Leader of the Fire Gate Clan and heir to that accursed lineage, before the spirits of their ancestors.

As the Dalai Lama's forces receded into the distance, the Grand Sorceress's voice reached the Blood Lord.

"Does that leave only the East Gate?"

"I'll send two Black Ghosts to the East Gate."

"Two? An awkward number. The Slaughter Saint might even take them down."

"But that won't happen. I'll order them to avoid a direct fight with the Slaughter Saint as much as possible and stick to a cautious attack."

"I take back what I said about the number being awkward."

The Grand Sorceress's lips curved softly beneath her veil.

"It's just the right number to let the Slaughter Saint leave his post to rescue the South Gate when it's in danger."

The Blood Lord gave a faint smile to match hers.

"And that will keep them from suspecting us."

If Dark Heaven sent no significant force to the East Gate, that alone would arouse suspicion.

But if they sent a substantial force and merely kept the pressure a little lighter, the troops at the East Gate, including the Slaughter Saint, would have some room to breathe. They would have time to look around.

Time to help their allies elsewhere, who would be on the verge of collapse.

The gap left at that moment would be the crack that brought down that massive, solid dam in an instant.

Whoosh!

Wind and rain whipped at the Blood Lord's clothes.

An ordinary person would have been soaked through and shivering from the cold that bit to the bone. The Blood Lord smiled and reached out his hand.

An east wind.

A fiercer east wind than ever was blowing along a tributary of the Yellow River.

And with it came more guests, riding the surging river waters to bring this battle to its grand finale after the Potala Palace.

Preee!

An eagle flew in from the east through the dark, rain-filled sky. It gave a powerful cry and landed on the Blood Lord's shoulder.

Bones showed white through its body in patches, and its blood-red eyes gleamed.

The Blood Lord knew what good news the eagle's arrival heralded. He stroked the hilt of the sword at his waist and murmured, "The time has come."

Chapter 1103

One Against a Thousand.

Just a few years ago, my life couldn't have been further from the meaning of those four words.

I'd scraped together some secondhand gear at a bargain price after a few rounds of haggling. I couldn't even afford a decent supply of the cheapest potions. The most I could handle was a few dozen small monsters in the dark, damp caves inside the subspaces known as Gates.

But a lot had changed since then.

More than I could put into words.

Thwack!

The rusty iron sword I swung on instinct sank into the crown of an enemy approaching from the side. His skull split, and bright red blood sprayed in every direction.

Plop.

A sticky, hot sensation brushed my cheek.

Once, that chilling touch would have made me flinch. Then the foul stench that crawled into my nose would have made me recoil again.

But that rookie Hunter, who'd thrown up at the horrible stench of blood he'd never smelled before, existed only in my memories now.

Thrust!

I drove my blade into the throat of an enemy charging straight at me, twisted it, and yanked it free. Blood poured from the gaping wound.

Grrk.

His body trembled as a wet rattle rose from his throat.

But to the fanatics, drunk on years of brainwashing and the strength of the Temporary Strength Pills, their comrade's gruesome death was martyrdom—and another chance to catch me off guard.

Shh-shh-shhk!

Blood-red Sword Energy rained down from every direction. The dense, destructive strands tangled together like a net and closed over my entire body.

Or at least, that was what it must have looked like to them.

Tap.

One step.

With that single step, the space between my enemies and me vanished.

I spun, and the iron sword in my hand traced a perfect, deadly arc.

Whoosh!

For an instant, the world seemed to stop.

The enemies realized that instead of retreating, I'd plunged straight into their midst. Their eyes slowly widened.

And then—

BOOM!

As the Sword Energy they'd already unleashed exploded, dozens of heads shot into the air like fireworks.

Shhk, fwoosh!

Red.

Everything I could see. The whole world.

Yet even now, every sense and every part of my body kept working without pause.

Whoosh.

Everything caught in the diagonal sweep of my sword split apart.

As I crossed the rising mound of corpses, sticky blood and screams—darker still—spilled around my feet.

Thwack! Thrust-thrust!

I cut, stabbed, and smashed without pause.

It didn't matter what I held.

An axe, a sword, even an oddly shaped weapon like a mace or a scythe—all of them were made to kill.

Crack!

A storm of blood and flesh swept through the air.

The weapons left to rust deep in Xining's armory became masterworks steeped in a craftsman's blood and sweat the moment they landed in my hands. They might break against Sword Energy, but they fulfilled their purpose to the end.

They took my enemies' lives, just as their owner intended.

…!

…!!

Shouts rang out from the enemies surrounding me and the allies on the wall above.

But I couldn't make out what any of them were saying.

My ears felt muffled, though my senses were sharp enough to catch every sound. The world before my eyes moved so slowly it was almost boring, yet every detail was clear.

I had no idea how many enemies I'd taken down or how many weapons I'd broken.

I was certain of only one thing.

Insight.

I was climbing toward another moment of enlightenment.

Wrapped in a fog of No-self, forgetting not only what was happening around me but even myself, I moved through a battlefield where life and death hung in the balance.

More. Just a little more.

As if bewitched, I kept repeating the words to myself.

At some point, everything around me had begun to feel hazy, like a dream.

A sensation I couldn't tell from pain or pleasure ran down my spine like an electric current.

I'd felt it before.

Now the Trance was more intense than ever, taking over my entire body.

Come.

As though they'd heard the quiet whisper in my mind, the enemies charged at me as one. They recited those eight words, that curse of a creed—"Heaven above and earth below, all demons bow!"—then roared and swung their weapons with all their might.

In the same instant, every one of them became a lonely soul.

Shhk. Shhk. Shhk.

Was this what the prophet in the old myths had been like?

Everything split apart as I strode forward without hesitation.

There was no sea before me, but the blood pouring from my enemies surged like waves. It was another kind of Red Sea.[3822]

And at the end of those red waves spilling away on either side, an insight awaited —one that would lift me to a higher level.

I can do this. I know I can.

Instinct spread over my fading reason.

Without looking, I dodged a blade swung at me from behind. With one stroke, I cut down five enemies charging from the side and the front.

But still, it wasn't enough.

I suddenly wanted this dreamlike sensation to last forever. This dream belonged only to me, and it was the sweetest sleep I'd ever known.

Even if I woke from it, I'd sell my soul just to see this story through to the end.

If I could make the insight drawing closer with every step my own, I could fall into this same sweet sleep whenever I wanted.

But then I remembered something I'd briefly forgotten.

If there was someone dreaming, then there was someone who could wake them.

Whooooooosh!

[3822] In the biblical book of Exodus, Moses parts the Red Sea to let the Israelites pass.

A sharp whistle cut through the distant echo that every other sound had become.

The ferocity in it, the enormous force drawing closer by the moment, dragged me out of my dream and hurled me into reality.

Along with someone's urgent, unfinished shout, suddenly bursting from somewhere in the open air.

"Dodge—!"

At that very moment—

Fwoosh.

The fog of No-self that had taken over my mind and body scattered in an instant.

No—it burst apart.

At the same time, a blood-red flash hurtled toward me from far away, its dazzling light staining my vision a thick red.

"…!"

My eyes widened. An alarm blared in my head, whispering:

Too late. You can't dodge it.

The flash was terrifyingly fast. Torn from that sweet sleep and thrown straight into reality, I couldn't move quickly enough to evade it.

Unlike the person who'd warned me half a beat earlier—who might have been watching over me all along.

Whoosh!

In the slowed-down world, I saw someone drop through the air.

A snow-white blade blocked the flash, which was already almost at my nose. Violet Sword Force scattered around it like flower petals.

Cheongpung.

The instant his name surfaced in my frozen thoughts—

BOOM!

A tremendous shock wave shook the air with a roar like the sky splitting apart.

Cough.

In the pale dust cloud that covered everything, Jin Taekyung gave a dry cough, blinked dazedly, and wondered:

Am I still alive?

The question had come to him suddenly. The answer came at once.

Pains large and small stabbed through his body like needles, accompanied by a System alert only he could hear.

No—*warning sirens* would be more accurate.

Beep! Beep-beep!

Trying to ignore the sirens drilling into his ears, Jin Taekyung struggled to his feet.

Pat-pat.

Stone dust slid off his body.

He felt heavy. Everything hurt.

Maybe it was because he'd suddenly woken from a Trance in which every sense had been pushed to its limit.

His body sagged like waterlogged cotton. But despite the barrage of warning sirens, he didn't seem to have any serious injuries.

He had the person who'd blocked the flash for him at the last moment to thank for that.

"Cheongpung."

His tired, cracked voice slipped past his lips. But in the dust cloud, so thick he couldn't see a hand in front of his face, all he heard were groans from people he couldn't identify.

"…Cheongpung?"

He called several more times. When no answer came, dread crept over him.

Jin Taekyung took a deep breath and swept out his arm, its sleeve already torn to shreds.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded outward. A gust imbued with internal energy drove away some of the dust, revealing what lay beyond it.

A gaping hole in the city wall, wide enough for five grown men to stand shoulder to shoulder. Allies lay sprawled all around it, groaning in pain.

But there was still no sign of Cheongpung.

Dammit.

Jin Taekyung clenched his teeth without realizing it.

Then he stretched out his hand toward the enemies charging through the ruins of the broken wall and the dust cloud.

More precisely, toward his beloved weapon, which lay behind them.

Vooooom.

His Middle Dantian opened. With a low hum, a spear buried deep in the ground shot upward and returned to its master's grasp.

It pierced every obstacle in its path.

Crack!

Blood spouted into the air.

Dozens of enemies, their spirits high as they charged, fell like rotten logs. In that brief opening, the allies formed ranks and fought with all their might to fill the gap.

Clang-clang!

Thrust!

“Gaaagh!”

“Hold them! Don’t let a single one through!”

“Cough—Archers! Where are the archers?”

Chaos spread in an instant.

Even as the melee broke out around the breached wall, Jin Taekyung cut down enemies with all his strength and shouted one person’s name.

“Young sir! Cheongpung!”

But no matter how keenly he strained his senses, there was no answer.

Only the screams and shouts of friend and foe rang out around him. That damned innocent voice was nowhere to be heard.

His heart pounded like thunder. With every moment, it grew harder to breathe.

…No way.

No. It couldn’t be.

Cheongpung—he wasn’t the kind of guy who’d go down this easily.

Like the hero in a fairy tale, he’d find some way to survive and live happily ever after.

Then why?

Why did this inexplicable dread keep growing heavier and darker?

“You… bastards!”

Jin Taekyung charged with a furious shout.

It was anger at the invaders who’d caused all this—but also blame directed at himself, the idiot who’d been consumed by a single-minded pursuit of enlightenment.

And the dazzling point of his spear, cutting through the enemy and raising a storm of blood, was drawing closer to one person approaching at a leisurely pace.

The Blood Lord.

Chapter 1104

Splash. Splash.

Footsteps crossed ground covered in blood, rainwater, and countless corpses. Each one landed with a peculiar weight.

Tens of thousands.

No—even on this vast battlefield, where friend and foe together numbered well over a hundred thousand, his presence was utterly overwhelming.

Vooooom.

Qi spread through the space around him with every step.

Even now, rain and arrows poured unceasingly from the sky, only to bounce off an invisible barrier of energy. The Dark Heaven followers charging toward the collapsed western wall split to either side and prostrated themselves.

As if bewitched, they murmured their eight-character creed.

“Heaven above and earth below.”

“All demons bow!”

It was reverence.

Reverence offered to the true ruler of this world, their god—and permitted only to the six Apostles he had personally favored.

The creed, begun with a few quiet murmurs, soon became a tremendous roar that swallowed the battlefield.

…!

…!!

A ripple became a current, then a wave sweeping in every direction.

The pounding rain, the thunder flashing between the dark clouds, even the arrows raining down to fill the sky—nothing could stop the creed pouring from their lips.

“Now! Attack!”

“Archers! Loose together!”

Shhk! Thud-thud-thud!

Blades flashed, and heads flew across the battlefield.

Nor was that all.

Severed arms and legs plunged into the mud. Arrows streaked in like flashes of light and buried themselves in backs and waists.

But that was all.

Even when their limbs were cut off, even when arrowheads pierced their backs and poked out through their chests, they stubbornly continued reciting the creed.

Right up to the moment death fell over them.

“Heaven above and earth below—cough. All demons bow…”

Thud.

Only after forcing out the last words, blood pouring from him, did the Dark Heaven follower die. The Kunlun Sect Daoist who had stabbed him through the chest stood with trembling lips.

"P-Primordial Heavenly Venerable.[3823]"

A wave of fanaticism beyond words.

And fanatics who didn't even fear death were everywhere.

No—every enemy darkening this vast battlefield was like that.

"This… What in the world is this?"

The words someone managed to squeeze out spoke for them all. They carried the utmost fear and horror a person could feel.

Splash. Clatter.

Weapons slipped from suddenly slack hands and sank into the mud.

For an instant, some of the Murim warriors and imperial troops lost their will to fight without even realizing it. Their trembling eyes stared blankly at the enemy.

They were afraid. So afraid they shuddered.

Not of some huge, savage monster, but of people who looked just like them.

Those mad fanatics, stripped of the joy, anger, sorrow, and pleasure every human being ought to feel, who followed only the Lord of Heaven with blind devotion.

And at their center, at the head of their ranks, walked a man wreathed in rippling, blood-red qi.

"What a bunch of worthless bastards."

His soft sneer revealed a row of white teeth.

At the same time, as the Blood Lord gently extended his fingertips, countless weapons that had been rolling across the ground rose upright.

No—they shot forward at their new master's command.

Toward the enemies frozen in place.

"You don't deserve to live."

At that moment—

Pa-pa-pa-pat!

Hundreds of weapons tore through the air at once.

A wave of steel swept through the ruins of the collapsed wall.

Those facing that blinding flash had no choice left. They weren't granted time to close their eyes, let alone draw one last breath.

All they could do was stare, eyes wide, at the death bearing down on them.

Then a streak of searing wind swept over their heads.

Gooooom.

[3823] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is one of the Three Pure Ones, the highest deities in Daoism.

Space warped.

Terrifying heat and dark blue light-flames filled everyone's sight.

And at last—

Fwoosh—KRAAASH!

The wave of steel met a wall of fire.

They struck each other head-on, unleashing the unimaginable power held within them in a burst of blinding light and sound.

Rumble-rumble-rumble…!

Would a volcano, ripe to erupt and roaring awake from a long sleep, sound like this?

Would a storm like this sweep across the land if an ancient giant exhaled with all its might?

No one could say.

No one, that is, except the two people standing tall as iron towers in the fierce light and shock wave that heated and drove back everything within dozens of jang.[3824]

"Good. You, at least, deserve to live."

The Blood Lord brought the edge of his hand down as he murmured. The dust cloud coiling around the western wall split apart, revealing what it had concealed.

A young man, drenched from head to toe in blood and rain, stood perfectly steady, aiming a pure silver-white spear at him.

"Which is precisely why I can't let you live."

Admiration tinged the Blood Lord's voice as he regarded the young man.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung."

At that moment, Jin Taekyung's tightly closed lips parted.

"Appreciate the sudden worship, but…"

Squelch.

He pulled out the shards of blades that had somehow pierced his body in several places as they flew through the wall of fire, then continued:

"No matter how I look at it, you don't deserve to live, you son of a bitch. That's why you have to die."

His voice was calm. Flames streamed from his eyes.

The Blood Lord gave a quiet laugh as he looked at him.

"Do you think you can do that? In your current condition?"

The Blood Lord wasn't exaggerating.

Jin Taekyung's appearance alone made him look like a man drenched in blood.

Given how many enemies he had cut down, that was only natural. But that didn't mean he'd come away unscathed.

[3824] A jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

He was exhausted and injured, too.

So were the others now rising one by one behind his back, which stood as imposing as a mountain.

But Jin Taekyung wasn't afraid.

He had already been afraid enough.

He had acknowledged and accepted every negative feeling that had weighed down his body and mind.

And so he managed a faint smile even as the Blood Lord approached.

"Sure, you could think that. But you know something?"

"What are you talking about?"

"Your precious friends all pulled that same shit on me before they died."

"…!"

"That's what you call a death flag, you moron. Ah, would you even understand if I explained it?"

Jin Taekyung laughed. Whatever his words meant, the sneer vanished from the Blood Lord's face.

"But I'm different from those idiots. I gave up on the idea of halfheartedly letting you live long ago."

Fwoosh.

Blood-red qi rose in wisps with every step he took.

His red-glinting eyes reflected only Jin Taekyung.

"You die today. No question."

"Wouldn't the Lord of Heaven be upset to hear that? He must've been fond of you, raising you as his obedient little dog."

"He will understand. This choice I make today comes from loyalty alone."

"Is that so? Or is that just what you hope?"

"What?"

The Blood Lord stopped walking for an instant. Jin Taekyung's voice slid into his ear.

"You don't think he'll understand. You think you're screwed if he finds out, so you're going ahead and doing it anyway. You even sent the Grand Sorceress far away, just in case."

"…!"

"Why are you staring at me with those rabbit eyes? You look disgusting enough already. Anyone would think you'd been slapped awake from a good night's sleep. Hadn't you already got a rough picture of it in your dream?"

Crunch.

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth without realizing it.

It wasn't Jin Taekyung's relentless taunts that made him do it. It was the truth he'd tried to ignore, stabbing into his heart like an awl.

"You know perfectly well what your master—that damned Lord of Heaven—wants most."

He had to refute him.

That insolent brat was openly insulting the master he worshiped like a god and questioning his intentions. The Blood Lord should tear his mouth apart right now and rip out that wicked tongue.

But he couldn't refute him.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung.

The Blood Lord had a vague sense that everything coming from that impertinent mouth was true.

He didn't know when it had begun. He hadn't even been told why.

But everything that had led them here pointed to one painful truth.

"What your master wants most isn't the world. It sure as hell isn't the lives of hunting dogs he uses and throws away, like you."

Jin Taekyung's voice burrowed into his ears. The truth in it shook him to the core.

"It's me. Only me."

"…!"

"So go on, try to kill me. If I can screw the Lord of Heaven over by using you, I don't care how it happens."

At that instant, the Blood Lord's slowly reddening eyes turned completely bloodred, their white pupils swallowed up.

And countless corpses scattered across the ground within some ten jang[3825] convulsed and spewed blood.

Swoosh.

The blood mixed with rainwater writhed as if alive and gathered at one man's feet.

As he began walking again, it flowed together and joined, climbed his calves, and wrapped around his entire body.

No.

It was absorbed into him.

As if it had been part of him since the distant past.

Fwoosh.

Feeling an endless surge of vitality and strength rise from deep within him, the Blood Lord's eyes blazed red.

"I heard your last words."

[3825] A jang is ten ja, approximately 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

Jin Taekyung stared blankly at the sight he hadn’t expected. Then he smacked his lips.

“Uh, could I maybe say a little more?”

The Blood Lord answered that ridiculous question with a massive flash of blood-red light.

Whoooosh!

In an instant, the world turned red.

Chapter 1105

Was it because Xining had endured one foreign invasion after another over the years?

The four walls surrounding the city now ran a full ten ri[3826] in length, enclosing a vast area behind fortifications whose strength was rarely seen even in the Central Plains.

But everything had its advantages and drawbacks.

The walls had been reinforced little by little over time, making them better at keeping invaders out. They had also given the defenders far more ground to cover.

To communicate across those distances, the defenders relied on war drums and flags stationed along the walls.

But at this moment, the blood-red flash that suddenly erupted in the west rendered them all useless.

Fwoooosh.

Would it look like this if dozens—hundreds—of sunsets overlapped?

In the slowing world, countless eyes widened at a sight none of them could describe.

The soldiers on a dozen or more watchtowers, beating their assigned war drums and waving their flags with all their strength.

The people hiding in Xining's Inner City, clutching their families and peering through cracks in the doors.

The combined forces of the imperial troops and Murim warriors, fighting back the enemies surging toward them like waves—even the Supreme Peak masters at the heart and forefront of their ranks, cutting down enemy after enemy without pause.

And the moment they all felt a chill climb their spines—

Pop.

The blood-red flash rising over the western wall swelled.

No—it exploded in a vivid, horrifying burst of red light.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A roar left their ears ringing.

The ground shook. The entire stone wall trembled.

Then a colossal shock wave surged over the western wall and crashed down on the people frozen like statues.

"Watch out—!"

KA-BOOOOM!

[3826] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi); ten li is about 5 km (3.1 mi).

The rushing wind swallowed someone's single shout and swept across everything.

The North Gate was no different.

Dust, shattered rock, even blades that had lost their owners flew through the air. Everyone ducked and threw themselves toward cover.

Everyone except one man, still holding the front line.

Fwoosh—BOOM!

He drove out a fist, and flames burst forth, devouring the space before him.

Even that storm, like a natural disaster, bowed before the heat. Everything hurtling toward the defenders at the North Gate evaporated in an instant.

Shhhhh.

Ash drifted slowly away on the now-gentle breeze.

But the eyes of the man who had protected his allies from the unexpected threat—Fire King Jeok Cheongang—were more somber than ever.

…What in the world was that?

Though he held the chief seat among the Ten Kings, he had already reached a realm where he could stand shoulder to shoulder with the Three Saints.

He could feel it against his skin, with every one of his senses: the immense power contained in that distant blood-red flash.

And if the blast had reached the North Gate, more than two hundred jang[3827] away, what state must the West Gate—the source of it all—be in?

Blood Lord, how did you…?

Jeok Cheongang bit his lip without realizing it.

The Blood Lord's martial prowess had advanced unmistakably since their encounter at Mount Song. But what weighed on his heart was the voice of someone he couldn't stop thinking about.

"I'll take the West Gate."

Jin Taekyung.

When his Disciple had said that just before the battle, Jeok Cheongang had answered without a moment's hesitation.

"Absolutely not. Instead of spouting that nonsense, do one more complete circulation. And don't go getting yourself stabbed because you were fooling around."

"My internal energy's in great shape, and I can take a few stabs. So I'll take responsibility for the West Gate."

"I said no."

"Why not?"

[3827] One jang is ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Two hundred jang is about 606 m (1,990 ft).

"You have to ask? That damned bastard has been mine for a long time. Today, I'll finally collect the blood debt from that day."

Jeok Cheongang's answer had been both true and untrue.

He did want revenge for Hong Dao, his old friend. But the more important reason was that the enemy's main force, including the Blood Lord, was stationed at the West Gate.

His Disciple was a reckless brat who'd long since thrown manners out the window. But he was his one and only Disciple.

He'd become more precious to Jeok Cheongang than anything else in the world. Jeok couldn't leave him alone in the most dangerous place.

Of course, Taekyung knew his Master far too well for Jeok Cheongang to hide that bashful concern behind roundabout words.

"There you go worrying again. You don't have to do that anymore."

"Worry? Don't be ridiculous. Just know that it's absolutely out of the question."

"I'll be fine. I have no intention of dying a pointless death. Do you think I'm crazy? I wouldn't be doing this if I didn't have something to count on."

"And what would that be?"

"You know already. As long as the Lord of Heaven wants me this badly, those guys can't lay a finger on me. Well, I might get a little hurt."

"That…"

Even Jeok Cheongang couldn't easily argue with that.

Ever since the incidents at Mount Song and Sichuan, powerful enemies—including the Southern Heaven Demon Empress—had been decidedly reluctant to take Jin Taekyung's life. The battle in Gansu had confirmed his suspicions.

Seeing his Master waver, Jin Taekyung drove in the final nail.

"No matter which gate I take, they'll follow me. I'm their most important target. So I might as well take the West Gate—it's the best-defended. Right?"

Every word he'd said had been right from beginning to end. In the end, Jeok Cheongang had no choice but to give in and head reluctantly to the North Gate.

But—

I shouldn't have done it.

Now he regretted that decision with all his heart.

He'd judged wrong.

The Blood Lord's martial prowess far exceeded anything he'd imagined, and Jin Taekyung, knowing exactly how his Master would react, had lied without batting an eye.

At this rate… that boy's in danger.

The attack they had all just witnessed could only have come from someone intent on killing.

So, though his body had grown young again, his heart was still that of an old man. Feeling himself grow impatient, Jeok Cheongang turned toward the west.

No—he was about to turn.

Until the next instant, when he sensed a sharp thread of killing intent shooting like a needle from beyond the wall.

"Where are you rushing off to, donor[3828]?"

The voice was low.

Yet the several jiazi[3829] of internal energy within it were enough to shake the area around the North Gate.

So was the terrifying aura emanating from the old monk standing atop a colossal elephant, the likes of which Jeok Cheongang had never seen even at the Nanman Beast Palace.

"If you leave now, donor[3830], I'll have come all this way for nothing."

His frame was tiny, his skin deeply wrinkled with age.

But his presence was like that of a giant, and Jeok Cheongang already knew who he was.

He also knew what it meant that this old monk—the Dalai Lama, Palace Lord of the Potala Palace—had appeared at the North Gate leading all those troops.

"…You planned this. From the beginning."

The words escaped him in a low groan.

Then the Dalai Lama spoke, turning his ominous suspicion into certainty.

"The Fire Gate Clan's line will end. Right here, today."

At that moment—

Bwaaaaaaa!

A war horn sounded. As the Potala Palace forces surged toward him, Jeok Cheongang gritted his teeth without realizing it.

Crack.

His lips went white. His nails dug deep into his skin, and hot blood ran from beneath them. His turmoil had no other outlet.

It wasn't too late.

He had to go. Even now.

To his Disciple. To Jin Taekyung.

But—

"P-Potala Palace! They've joined the battle!"

"Arrows! Bring more arrows!"

"Form a defensive line! Don't retreat, even if it costs us our lives!"

[3828] "Donor" translates *siju*, a Buddhist form of address for a layperson.

[3829] A *jiazi* is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

[3830] "Donor" translates *siju*, a Buddhist form of address for a layperson.

“Sir Jeok, we don’t have time to hesitate!”

Shouts and screams from every direction held him in place.

Eyes full of fear, resolve, or faith seemed to seize his hands and close around his throat. The urgent voice of Perfected Being Hyeoncheon, defending the North Gate alongside him, pierced his ears.

What would he have done? What would that boy have done?

Jeok Cheongang put the question to himself and squeezed his eyes shut.

In that brief, profound darkness, he recalled the conversation he’d had with his Disciple the day before.

“I never wanted to be a hero.”

“That doesn’t matter. You don’t become a hero just because you want to. You earn the right when the world calls you one.”

“Like people call you a Great Hero, Old Master?”

“What?”

“You just said it yourself. You didn’t set out to follow some great cause. You just went where your feet led you, where the wind took you, and before you knew it, people were calling you a Great Hero.”

“…!”

He remembered it clearly.

The bright smile Taekyung had given him when he was left speechless. His playful expression. His clear eyes.

Perhaps that was what Jeok Cheongang feared more than anything else.

Perhaps the thought that he might never see that face again had come first.

But when Jeok Cheongang had asked whether he was still afraid of the enemy, his Disciple had nodded without hesitation and added:

“Even so, I won’t turn away from that fear.”

Calm. Resolute.

And everything that had happened that day was the answer to the question Jeok Cheongang had just asked himself.

Fwoooosh.

In an instant, tremendous heat swallowed the space.

His eyelids rose slowly. His eyes glowed red with heat, blazing like flames.

He faced the Dalai Lama and the Twelve Secret Monks flying through the air toward him.

Toward the two Black Ghosts who had appeared, and the vast enemy army surging in behind them.

Grnnnnk.

As the space warped under the unbearable heat, the giant of fire roared with all his might.

“Come!”

As if he meant to burn the whole world.

“This old man is Jeok Cheongang, the eighteenth Sect Leader of the great Fire Gate Clan—the Fire King!”

He hoped his roar would reach his Disciple.

Chapter 1106

BOOM!

The flash that filled my vision was red as blood.

Pwoom!

Unfathomable power seethed in every strike.

Krrrunch!

The world kept turning upside down, then righting itself.

No—not the world. Me.

Fwooooooosh—BOOM!

A tremendous shock shot up my spine and spread through my entire body.

After dozens of exchanges in the space of a lightning flash, I ended up buried deep in the layered rubble of the wall.

Cough.

Blood surged up against my will and spilled past my lips.

A System warning chime sounded through the ringing in my ears. The pain coming from every part of my body told me the warning was real.

I'm sure I heard something.

I muttered it weakly to myself, remembering a familiar voice that had rung out somewhere in the distance just before the assault sent me flying.

But I must have imagined it.

One of those hallucinations that came to me every now and then when I was exhausted and hurting.

"…Damn it."

Blood kept welling up. My torn-up hands tingled.

Even so, I forced my aching body upright with a quiet curse.

No. I had to.

If I didn't stop that monster, none of the thousands of allies risking their lives to defend the West Gate could.

Splash. Splash.

Heavy footsteps approached, neither fast nor slow.

With every step, the blood swirling ankle-deep in the downpour trembled like a living thing.

Shhhhhh.

It was enough to chill anyone who saw it.

Hundreds of snakes, red from head to tail, seemed to slide across the surface of the water.

And at the end of their eerie advance stood a monster, ready to take in more power.

Hssss.

The blood seeped into his skin as though it had never existed outside him.

Then the monster's eyes blazed a fiercer red through the pounding rain.

They were fixed on one person among the countless allies frozen like statues.

Me.

"Didn't I tell you?"

His low voice reached me clearly.

The monster of blood had absorbed every drop within a radius of more than a hundred feet, devouring the life and strength it held. He gazed at me, eyes bright with delight.

"You can never be my equal. No one on this battlefield can."

Veterans who'd survived for years in Murim, a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords, had a saying.

Too much confidence became conceit and arrogance. Go further still, and it became hubris. Those were the feelings a martial artist had to guard against most.

And if an enemy fell prey to them, you seized on that weakness to find a way out alive.

The advice had been passed down among martial artists like a maxim. Jeok Cheongang had often told me much the same thing.

But—

This isn't conceit.

I knew it instinctively.

No—I was facing that monster myself. I knew better than anyone.

This wasn't arrogance or hubris. It was certainty.

A certainty even I, who had created more possibilities and variables than anyone under heaven, couldn't deny.

The monster who had become the Blood Lord in the truest sense approached, crushing everything around him with power and presence greater than anyone else's on this battlefield.

Krrr.

The air trembled. The ground shook.

Neither the torrential rain nor the arrows loosed by archers who'd scraped together their courage atop the parts of the wall still standing could touch a hair on his head.

They had only irritated him.

Vmmmm.

The hundred or so arrows that had stopped above the Blood Lord's head as though caught by an invisible hand trembled. Then their points turned.

Toward the insects who deserved to die for daring to bar the path of a monster who had drawn close to the absolute ruler.

"Get out of the way!"

The warning burst from my lips on instinct.

Fwhoosh! Thud-thud-thud!

The arrows streaked through the air in a flash, their fierce whistle merging into one.

Through the shield-bearers protecting the archers with iron-plated shields. Through the archers sheltering behind them.

Through everything in their path.

Thud.

The unit commander at the front was the first to drop to one knee.

The others stared blankly at one another.

Eyes wide with disbelief, they looked back and forth between the huge holes in their bodies and the monster standing hundreds of feet away. Then they breathed their last.

"T-This can't be…"

Thump. Clatter.

One by one, bodies fell onto the ground slick with blood and rain.

Some stumbled backward in terror. Some tried to advance, refusing to accept that they were dying. Some crumpled where they stood without even a final cry.

They met death in different ways, but not one escaped it.

They all died.

Two hundred of our allies—archers, shield-bearers, even martial artists.

In a single instant.

Slide. Splash!

Someone whose name I didn't know rolled down from the wall and landed in a pool of blood.

"Heaven above and earth below."

In the suffocating silence that settled over everything, Dark Heaven's followers had entered past the broken ranks and wall ruins that had crumbled with the Blood Lord's arrival. As if bewitched, they began reciting their creed.

"All demons bow!"

They no longer shouted.

The killing intent they'd given off while struggling to cross the wall was gone, too.

Shhk!

They simply swung the blades in their hands without a word.

“Heaven above and earth below…!”

Rapture filled their faces as they marveled at the miracle before their eyes.

“All demons bow…!”

They praised the one ruler who wasn’t on this battlefield, yet could bring all under heaven to its knees from within that deep darkness.

Even if death awaited them.

Crunch!

“Hea—khhk. Lord of Heaven.”

Even when a stray blade cut their throats, when their arms and legs were severed, when their chests were pierced, they never lost the smiles etched across their lips.

The dozen fanatics charging at me without a hint of fear were no different.

“A-at last. The glory of martyrdom…”

Stab! Krrrunch!

In the end, humans were made of flesh. Once their heads were gone, they couldn’t speak.

It didn’t matter whether they’d taken a Temporary Strength Pill, drawing on strength beyond their limits at the cost of their lives, or swallowed anything else.

But why?

I’d swung my hand like a blade and taken their heads off in one stroke, yet I could still hear their unfinished words.

Over and over. Without a moment’s pause.

“These… crazy bastards.”

The curse slipped out between breaths that had somehow grown ragged.

It felt as though every drop of blood in my body had turned to ice.

I’d thought I’d seen and dealt with enough lunatics to last a lifetime.

The twenty-first-century world I’d been born and raised in had its own kind of barbarity, different from Murim’s.

Skyscrapers soared above the clouds. More than half a century had passed since humanity first ventured into space. A civilization combining cutting-edge science and Magic had grown brighter and more powerful than ever.

But none of that changed a thing.

The modern world was still full of madmen.

People were murdered in broad daylight. Judges’ gavels and reporters’ cameras swayed under the weight of money and liquor.

And that wasn’t all.

Dictators, relics of a bygone age, prepared for wars—and started them.

Plenty of people tried to bridge the distance between their religions and sects with missiles and terror instead of forgiveness and reconciliation.

In the world I'd seen, they were all fanatics.

Madmen who'd lost their minds by attaching themselves blindly to their own goals. They saw and felt only what they wanted, swaying as they got drunk on it.

Of course, the most extreme had been the fanatics who followed the Doppelganger. But now I could say this with certainty.

The madness I'd seen in them, in both its scale and its purity, was nothing next to that of the Dark Heaven followers before me.

And at the center of this bloody storm of madness, a monster came hurtling forward with the momentum of a great mountain.

"Have you ever seen moths?"

I could feel it.

The Blood Lord was at ease, but he hadn't let his guard down.

His red eyes were fixed solely on me, as though he had no interest in the battles raging around us. They brimmed with certainty and killing intent.

"I have. Countless times, before the Tianshan Mountains fell under that person's control. I saw those foolish things fly toward torches and burn to death."

I didn't answer.

Instead, I drove the shaft of White Flame, still in my grip, deep into the ground at my feet. Then I kicked up the weapons strewn around me and sent them flying at him.

Fwooooooosh—BOOM!

Krrrunch!

The blades, wreathed in Force, cut through the air one after another. Then an immense shock wave slammed into the space around them with a deafening roar.

Not where I'd aimed—the Blood Lord—but somewhere in the air and ground.

"But one day, while watching the moths, a question occurred to me."

The Blood Lord swung his Red Blade at lightning speed, casually knocking aside everything flying toward him, and continued in a clear voice.

"Did they fly toward the torch knowing they would burn to death? Or did they fly toward it because they didn't know?"

Crunch!

I cut down the enemies charging at me from every direction. After the wall, our ranks were now collapsing fast, too.

The fanatics came on crying out for martyrdom. The sight of them—and the wave of fear they stirred up—was overpowering even the effect of One Against a Thousand.

“I still haven’t found the answer. No—I never bothered looking. It wasn’t long before I met that person and gained enough power that I had no need to wonder how moths felt.”

At that moment—

Whoooooom!

The Blood Lord lifted his Red Blade high. A massive Force surged along its scarlet edge.

An energy unlike anything I’d ever seen—or imagined could exist.

“But I think you might know the answer.”

Certainty in himself.

Killing intent sharp as a blade. Hatred beyond anger. The elation of finally achieving his purpose.

All of it—every feeling, every ounce of his aura and power—was directed at me.

My breath caught. My hand trembled.

But I was ready.

I’d prepared the best strike I could manage. Perhaps my last.

I took a deep breath and said what had been on the tip of my tongue.

“I’m not one of them.”

“What?”

“I’m the kind of bastard who doesn’t burn to death even if he flies into the flames. Who flies in first whether he knows what’ll happen or not. That’s me.”

“…!”

The silence felt like an eternity, though it lasted only an instant.

At its very end, the Blood Lord answered.

No—he moved.

So did I.

Pop.

More than a hundred feet of space vanished between us in an instant, and his Red Blade carved a massive blood-red line.

Chapter 1107

Murim warriors spend their whole lives lingering at the crossroads of life and death.

Some live out their natural years thanks to their skill and the luck they were born with. Others get dragged into some petty squabble and die like dogs in an instant.

That was probably why.

They lived closer to death than anyone, so they'd even coined a grand term like *life-and-death duel*, trying to make their own uncertain end sound a little more solemn.

But at some point, I realized that no matter how many flowery words people used, or how many valorous titles they bestowed on one another, the nature of it never changed.

In the end, this was just a fight.

Each person gave everything they had to bring down the opponent in front of them, driven by their own cause, circumstances, or private feelings.

It could be fair. It could be unfair.

That was why it was a fight.

A simple, straightforward process: the one who was even half a step faster, ten geun[3831] stronger, and far more ruthless and calculating won.

And I knew that very well.

I knew how wide the gap was between my opponent and me. I knew the best I could do right now.

And the worst, too.

Watching the Blood Lord cross a dozen or so jang[3832] through the slowed world, I muttered to myself.

Did I regret this choice? Was I afraid of dying?

I didn't know.

More precisely, I didn't have enough time to answer.

Even in the sluggish flow of time, the Blood Lord moved like a flash of light—and I was definitely slower.

Half a step.

No. At least a full step stood between us now, a gap I could never close. It was an iron wall.

So there was nothing else I could do.

I could only charge at him like a moth.

[3831] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten geun is 6 kg (13.2 lb).

[3832] A jang is a traditional unit of length equal to ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A dozen jang is about 36 m (119 ft).

Before that torch, reeking of blood, swallowed everyone, I had to put it out with one last beat of my wings, giving it everything I had.

Grnnk.

Every muscle in my body contracted at once.

At the same time, the internal energy I had left—less than a third—surged from my Lower Dantian to my Middle Dantian, then awakened the hundreds of large and small acupoints and the Eight Extraordinary Meridians lying dormant in my body.

Hoo.

I was so hot I felt as if I'd become a fire dragon myself. If I opened my mouth and roared, lava might pour out.

But I couldn't do that.

I had only one chance to let that lava loose.

It wouldn't be my first time, but it was all but certain to be my last.

The System warning chime that suddenly pierced my ears seemed to say as much.

Beeeeeeep.

Slowed along with the passage of time, it stretched into a long ringing, like the flatline of a heart monitor announcing a patient's cardiac arrest. That hardly seemed an exaggeration.

One Annihilation.

The colossal mass of lava boiling up from deep within me held enough destructive power to turn even me to ash.

Fwoooosh.

Heat slowly surged outward, warping the space around me.

Flames that had seared my Lower Dantian, Middle Dantian, hundreds of acupoints, and Eight Extraordinary Meridians layered themselves over the spearhead.

All for one final chance.

This is it. The only way to bring him down.

Of course, this wasn't the first time I'd used One Annihilation against the Blood Lord.

During the Shaolin Bloodshed, he'd taken the full force of it and still gotten back up, thanks to his incredible regenerative ability.

But an almost unfathomable gulf separated the me who'd been stuck at the Peak realm back then from the me I was now.

One Annihilation had grown just as much—powerful enough to devour even its wielder's life.

Unlike last time, he won't get back up.

One blow would render even the Blood Lord's terrifying recovery useless.

Blue-black flames that would turn his body and even his soul to ash in an instant flickered along the spearhead of White Flame, drawn far back. And then—

Fssssss.

A sudden chill crept down my spine.

What was this feeling?

I was the archer. My body was the bow, and the string was already drawn all the way back.

All I had to do was let go.

All I had to do was thrust my spear at the Blood Lord, now just one jang[3833] away, as if to blow up the whole world—and it would all be over.

Then why, at the most important moment, had this inexplicable sense of wrongness come over me?

Fear of the death that was all but certain now?

Regret for the life I'd lived and the people I'd leave behind?

Or my life flashing before my eyes as I sensed the end?

No.

That wasn't it.

This feeling was different from any of those I'd experienced before.

It was a warning.

A signal from the other me—the one that followed nothing but instinct.

And at last, the moment reason and instinct met inside me—

…!

…!!

Time, held back until now, and everything around me—the noise and the surroundings—came crashing down all at once, like a massive wave breaking through a dam.

Through it all, a blurred afterimage flashed between the Blood Lord and me as we shot toward each other.

Fwoooosh!

From outside my field of vision came a fierce whistle, cutting through the wind and rain.

I realized too late that someone was there, clad from head to toe in pitch-black armor. No—*something*.

The blood in my body turned cold.

Black Ghost…!

So that was it.

[3833] A jang is a traditional unit of length equal to ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). A dozen jang is about 36 m (119 ft).

That was what the unease I'd felt earlier meant.

The card the Blood Lord had kept hidden until the very end. He had grown stronger than before, and his planning had grown sharper still.

He planned it. He'd been waiting for this moment from the start.

The realization struck like lightning through my skull.

Only then did I understand.

It wasn't the Blood Lord who'd let his guard down. It was me.

The other side could learn from past mistakes, too.

Despite his inhuman regenerative ability and overwhelming martial prowess, the Blood Lord had waited for One Annihilation until the very last moment, then put the Black Ghost he'd kept hidden in front of him as a shield.

As if he wouldn't allow even the smallest variable.

And the price of my carelessness was shoving me hard in the back, right at the edge of a cliff.

There was no other way.

I'd already come too far to turn back.

"Damn it."

With no choices left, I spat out the curse I'd been holding back and thrust my spear forward. My entire past and future rested on its tip.

Gooooom.

Space warped.

The fire dragon's flames let out a tremendous roar, flooding everything I could see in blue-black.

At the last moment, as that dreadful heat was about to devour everything in its path, a streak of light swept past the Black Ghost like an apparition.

Shhk.

A faint sound of air being cut—so faint I wouldn't have heard it if my senses hadn't been sharper than ever.

And it wasn't an apparition or a hallucination.

One Annihilation.

When that terrifying strike—the one that had briefly cornered him in the not-so-distant past—shot toward him, the Blood Lord thought:

It's over.

Certainty in a life-and-death duel was no different from poison.

But even he, who'd endlessly turned over the final moments of the four Demon Lords and the Demon Empress who had fallen to Jin Taekyung, couldn't help feeling certain now.

Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung.

His sickening history with that damned brat, who made him feel foul just to think about, ended here.

The plan was perfect. It was as good as done.

You'll never kill me.

There was no mistaking it: Jin Taekyung had grown beyond recognition.

And so, the Blood Lord had no doubt that the strike he couldn't begin to understand had grown terrifyingly powerful, too.

It had become so powerful that even the Blood Lord, who now considered himself all but immortal, had thought of death when he felt the unprecedented energy wrapped around the spearhead.

But this was as far as it went.

The lion uses all its strength, even when hunting a rabbit.

Even a predator gives everything it has to catch a single rabbit.

It had taken the loss of an arm and a long period of humiliation for the Blood Lord to learn that lesson and put it into practice. But thanks to that, he could avoid the sharp teeth the rabbit had hidden.

The one Black Ghost he'd kept by his side for this moment alone.

He'd sent as many as eight Black Ghosts to the three gates other than the West Gate, then entered through the breached wall alone. It was all to pin down the enemy and make that brat let his guard down.

So Jin Taekyung would focus solely on him.

So he would believe the Blood Lord was his only enemy.

And the Blood Lord's plan had worked.

No—more accurately, he thought it had worked.

The vast flames bursting from the spearhead swallowed the space around them. At that moment, a streak of light flew in from somewhere and swept past the Black Ghost that had moved between Jin Taekyung and the Blood Lord at his command.

Shhk.

…What?

A ripple of shock disturbed the Blood Lord's unwavering gaze.

His eyes trembled, then slowly turned to the Black Ghost's neck as it rose into the air.

In the gap between the two halves of its body, separated by empty space, a handful of purple Force scattered like flower petals.

That's…

There was no mistaking it.

That distinctive light, spreading like plum blossoms or the colors of the sunset, belonged to the Zaha Divine Technique alone.

Staring blankly at the scene, stunned as if the world had stopped, the Blood Lord remembered a face he'd momentarily forgotten.

The man bore a striking resemblance to the one who had taken his arm. Yet he'd vanished from the battlefield so anticlimactically that he'd hardly seemed worthy of inheriting that man's teachings.

But before the Blood Lord could speak the other brat's name, the blue-black flames swallowed the Black Ghost's body without a trace—and engulfed him.

KWA-AAAAA!

A colossal pillar of fire surged upward, sweeping across heaven and earth.

Chapter 1108

He was dead.

No—he'd thought he was dead.

Fifteen minutes earlier, the young man who had rushed in front of Jin Taekyung, lost in a Trance and unable to sense the danger, had been certain he was about to die.

But he hadn't.

A blood-red flash charged with an unprecedented force had struck him, followed by a tremendous impact that battered his entire body.

When he finally opened his eyes, clinging to the thread of consciousness that had briefly been severed, the young man buried beneath a pile of stones—or rather, Cheongpung—muttered to himself:

This is the most dangerous thing I've ever been through… No, it isn't.

If this had happened before—more precisely, if he hadn't gone through what happened on Mount Song—he might have trembled with fear.

Overwhelmed by the terror of death, something he'd never experienced before, and frozen by the killing intent and madness he'd never felt amid the clear streams and plum blossoms of Lotus Peak, he might have been unable to move.

But—

I have to move.

Things were different now.

The child who had wandered through Huashan's beautiful scenery had entered the martial world and learned how to run.

He'd faced the world's ugliness and learned what anger felt like. He'd spent time with good people and come to understand what it meant to do right by others.

So even knowing that countless threats and hardships awaited him, he could rise again.

That was the right path his grandfather had raised him to follow. It was the chivalry he had learned from watching Jin Taekyung.

Go. To my Benefactor. To them.

Cheongpung pushed himself to his feet, unsteady.

He shoved aside the stones weighing down his body and endured the pain of bones broken here and there, moving slowly.

And more stealthily than ever before.

"You want me to teach you martial arts?"

Perhaps it was the blood trickling from the large and small wounds etched across his body. In his wavering vision, a conversation he'd once had with the Slaughter Saint seemed to echo in his ears.

“Do you even know what you’re asking?”

“Uh, I think so.”

“Unbelievable. The Sword Saint’s Disciple, of all people, wants to become a mere assassin.”

“Huh?”

“You idiot. I don’t practice martial arts. I practice the art of killing. It’s not for someone like you.”

Back then, the Slaughter Saint had shaken his head with a bitter smile.

At least, until he heard Cheongpung’s reply.

“Huh. I don’t think so.”

“What?”

“My grandfather told me it’s not the tool that matters, but the person holding it. And there was an assassin I saw a long time ago who didn’t seem like the kind of person who’d hurt someone for no reason.”

“…!”

“Oh, and he said everyone I cross paths with in this world could become my teacher and Benefactor.”

“…You.”

“Please take care of me, Granduncle!”

Remembering how the Slaughter Saint had silently watched him, then spoken with an expression that grew complicated, Cheongpung let out a quiet breath.

Hoo.

His heart, pounding from pain and blood loss, grew calm. The blood flowing from his wounds gradually stopped, and he erased all trace of his presence.

“It won’t be easy to master even one technique. You don’t have the time, and the situation won’t allow for it.”

“Wow, so you’re saying yes, right? You are, aren’t you?”

“Damn it. Fine. But I have one condition.”

“A condition?”

“Never call me that again.”

“Yes, Little Master!”

“Damn it.”

“Oh. Sorry, Granduncle.”

“…Where in the world did the Sword Saint pick up a lunatic like you?”

The Slaughter Saint probably hadn’t known.

Before even a month of their journey had passed, he would ask that question again—but mean something entirely different by it.

“…Where in the world did the Sword Saint pick up a lunatic like this?”

“Grandpa said a stork brought me. My Benefactor said it was ovulation, fertilization, and implantation, but I couldn’t make heads or tails of it.”

“…I really can’t understand.”

“Right? I’d never heard such bizarre words in my life.”

“…It’s my first time, too. Seeing anything this bizarre.”

The Slaughter Saint’s bewildered face rose before Cheongpung’s eyes.

At the same moment, Cheongpung’s feet, now as light as feathers, touched a pool of blood.

No—they barely brushed it.

Shhk.

Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step.

The unique footwork technique created by the greatest assassin of all time—so stealthy that no other technique under heaven could match it—unfolded beneath Cheongpung’s feet.

“You were right, Granduncle. This really isn’t easy.”

“…Is that something someone who reached three-tenths mastery in only a month should be saying?”

It was the unique technique of none other than the Slaughter Saint, known as the greatest assassin of all time.

And yet Cheongpung had mastered Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step at a dazzling speed.

For someone else, a month might have been *only* a month. For him, it was a *whole* month.

“I like martial arts. A whole, whole lot.”

“That much I know… This is driving me mad. How is this even possible?”

It was possible.

To Cheongpung, all of it came as naturally as breathing.

He watched with his eyes and moved with his body, and before he knew it, the technique became his.

Not merely copied: it was reborn with Cheongpung’s own character woven into it, a new martial art that belonged to him alone.

Whoosh.

Cheongpung moved forward.

His steps were neither fast nor slow. With each one, it seemed that the fragrance of plum blossoms, perceptible only to him, spread through the air.

Dark Fragrance Drift.

The fragrance of Huashan’s plum blossoms spread through the pouring rain.

Joined with Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step, which Cheongpung had brought to nine-

tenths mastery over the past six months with the Slaughter Saint, it had grown quieter and more elusive still.

So much so that even with both eyes open, no one could clearly make out his presence.

Shh-shh-shh-shhk!

“Graaagh!”

Stab! Slice!

“Heaven above and earth below; all demons—Guh!”

The fighting all around had spun beyond anyone’s control, yet no one properly noticed Cheongpung slipping past them.

As he crossed the heart of the battlefield, he blended naturally into everything around him.

He was the rain falling ceaselessly over everyone’s heads. He was a Dark Heaven fanatic, drunk on madness and the effects of a Temporary Strength Pill—and he was one of the martial artists and soldiers trying to stop them.

He was a part of this chaotic battlefield, and the battlefield itself.

Moving in only one direction, toward only one person.

Benefactor.

Cheongpung saw him.

Gooooom.

Space warped as if gripped by an invisible hand. Jin Taekyung was about to unleash an appallingly immense force all at once.

The Blood Lord was charging toward him, while a pitch-black figure lunged from his blind spot as though it had been waiting for this very moment.

Too late.

His instincts whispered it to him.

It was a shame, but this wasn’t enough.

Cheongpung had neither the strength to bring down the Blood Lord nor the time.

But—

He can do it. My Benefactor can.

That wasn’t a guess. It was certainty.

His faith in Jin Taekyung didn’t waver in the slightest.

So Cheongpung shot forward without hesitation.

Toward the enormous flames erupting in a blinding flash.

Toward the Black Ghost, which had thrown its own body in the way as a shield to counter that unprecedented force.

Fwoosh.

Time slowed. Space disappeared.

Just before One Annihilation was unleashed, a flash slipped between his tightly shut eyelids and pierced his retinas like a needle.

But Cheongpung could feel it clearly.

The Black Ghost at the end of his path.

The single line his strike was drawing toward that pitiful being.

And then—

Shhk.

The moment he passed the Black Ghost with a cut almost too quiet to hear, a lightning-like shiver surged up his spine.

A shiver that wouldn't fade, not even in the dreadful heat swallowing the space he had just crossed.

I did it.

At the same moment, a colossal fire dragon swallowed the Black Ghost's body as it tilted helplessly.

No—more precisely, it swallowed the blood-red monster charging from behind it.

KWA-AAAAA!

Even as the overwhelming shock wave swept him away, Cheongpung laughed aloud.

He watched the Red Blade shatter beneath the pillar of fire that had finally burst forth.

But he didn't know.

At that very moment, one person was watching the blue-black flames dye everything around them.

Jin Taekyung's face had gone colder than ever.

Cough.

His skin had gone deathly pale, his eyes growing cloudy.

Yet even as he coughed up a doe[3834] of blood, Jin Taekyung forced his heavy eyelids open and watched the wave of fire he had unleashed.

He took in the surest information he could get—something only he could hear.

Beep! Be-be-beep!

He'd poured everything he had into that strike.

With a body emptied of strength and senses gone dry, he tried to understand what was happening.

But he couldn't see or hear.

It wasn't in any of the countless holographic windows floating before him. It wasn't among the System warnings sounding without pause in his ears.

The clear chime announcing the enemy's death never came.

[3834] A *doe* is a traditional Korean measure of volume, approximately 1.8 liters (0.48 US gal).

Not even as his legs gave way beneath him, the spear shaft the only thing keeping him upright.

Splash.

And as Jin Taekyung's knees plunged into a pool of blood—

Drip. Drip.

From within the wave of fire that had engulfed a radius of dozens of jang,[3835] the monster's charred body rose to its feet.

Thirst.

That was the first thing the Blood Lord felt when he regained consciousness.

What the hell happened?

He didn't know. He couldn't know.

He remembered nothing.

He couldn't even recall who he was or what kind of life he'd lived.

Only the instinct to quench this terrible thirst remained, controlling his body.

Scuff.

His unsteady footsteps sounded as dry as if he were walking through a desert.

Why?

The Blood Lord wondered blankly.

He'd been sure there was something somewhere around here that could quench his thirst.

He'd been sure of it.

Why?

He turned his head and looked around, but he couldn't see anything. His senses had failed, his retinas burned away, trapping him in pitch-black darkness.

All he could make out was a faint sound.

…!

…!!

A strange noise.

Yes, he remembered. Screams and the sound of steel scraping against steel.

And then, from the unknown thing that touched his skin, came a feeling that was familiar—and strangely dear.

Splash.

At that moment, forgotten sensations and memories awoke.

Something hot, wet, and sticky.

[3835] A *jang* is a traditional Korean measure of length, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

The Blood Lord remembered what this utterly familiar thing was.

Blood.

Something inside the human body. The source of his strength—and the only liquid that could quench his thirst now.

I'm thirsty.

Strange. Just thinking it was enough for him to feel the blood splattered across his body seeping into him.

As it did, his senses gradually sharpened.

But—

More. Give me more.

This wasn't nearly enough.

He needed far, far more blood.

"More!"

With the cry already escaping his lips, the Blood Lord swept his hand out with all his strength.

Grab.

At last, his fingertips touched someone's shoulder. At the same time, a voice rang more clearly in his ears, echoing like a distant sound.

"Blood Lord! Your subordinates will protect you—!"

But before the desperate voice could finish, the Blood Lord's teeth, already grown, sank into the man's throat.

Crunch!

He chewed and swallowed.

For greater strength. To quench his thirst.

Only then did the world around the monster grow bright.

Chapter 1109

The moment fierce flames swept through the battlefield, everyone—ally and enemy alike—thought the Blood Lord was dead.

That was how much power the strike had contained.

Even with his near-immortal regenerative ability, surviving that dreadful, hellish heat had seemed impossible.

But there was one exception.

Jin Taekyung had used even his own life as kindling to summon those flames.

Splash.

His knee sank into a pool of blood. Beyond the drifting ashes, the monster that had stopped just short of death began to rise.

Then a single shout burst from Jin Taekyung's lips, now pale as snow. He wrung it out with every ounce of strength he had left.

"Attack!"

The azure dragon's roar shook the air on every side, breaking the momentary silence and setting time in motion again.

The first to respond was another Divine Dragon, still hurtling away after being caught in the aftermath of One Annihilation.

"…!"

Cheongpung's eyes flew open.

The thrill and elation he'd felt just after cutting off the Black Ghost's head were gone.

Only overwhelming shock and confusion rushed in to take their place.

How is this even possible…!

He couldn't believe what he was seeing. But he had no choice but to accept it.

Gritting his teeth, Cheongpung twisted around.

Whoosh.

His body spun against the howling wind. He thrust out a foot and stepped into empty air.

No—he made it burst.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded.

The distance of some twenty jang[3836] closed in an instant, bringing the staggering monster sharply into view.

I'll kill him. No matter what!

Cheongpung's mind was cold as ice.

[3836] A *jang* is ten *ja*, or about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft). Twenty jang is about 60.6 meters (199 ft).

His instincts were screaming at him. If he didn't stop that terrible monster now, he might never get another chance.

He had to bring the creature down by any means necessary, before it recovered its original strength.

But another group of monsters awaited his descending sword. They went by a different name: fanatics.

"Stop him!"

"Heaven above and earth below; all demons—!"

Sh-sh-sh-shhk! Slice!

Purple Force flowed along Cheongpung's blade, cutting through flesh and bone without hesitation.

Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords.

Huashan's finest sword technique filled the air. Along the path traced by his blade, the Force of the Zaha Divine Technique blossomed and scattered like petals.

Beautiful, and sorrowful.

And more than anything, desperate.

Thud! Fwoosh!

He cut, and cut, and cut again.

They fell, and fell, and fell again.

But—

They're not backing down…

Cheongpung's face turned pale.

Everything around him was stained red. Blood poured out without pause, washing away the fragrance of his sword technique and obscuring the purple Force.

The defenders who had joined the fight were swinging their weapons with the resolve to die, but even so, the wall of fanatics held firm.

To them, death—the thing every living person feared—was sacred martyrdom.

"The great Lord of Heaven's power has descended upon this land! We will give our lives to protect His Apostle!"

"Lord of Heaven, lead us!"

The fanatics' spirits had never been higher than after witnessing the Blood Lord survive.

No—this had gone beyond madness.

To others, his survival was a strange and terrible calamity. To the fanatics, it was a miracle proving their faith had been right all along.

And amid that whirlpool of madness and death, Cheongpung could see the monster clearly.

A monster slowly retreating from the jaws of death, absorbing the blood of friend and foe pouring in from every direction.

Rustle.

New flesh began to grow over its charred body.

Crack.

Melted bone and muscle regenerated.

Pop. Pop.

Its lips, fused together above and below, came apart to reveal sharp white teeth.

A long, blood-red tongue flicked out between them, driven by an unbearable thirst.

"…More. Give me more."

The moment a voice like scraping metal slipped from the monster's parched lips, Cheongpung felt the blood in his whole body turn cold.

Already?

The sight was bizarre beyond words, and the recovery was far too fast. It was well beyond what he and the other allies had expected.

For a moment, he wondered whether they would be better off falling back, if that could delay the monster's recovery even a little.

But even in that fleeting moment, the mindless monster was regaining its original strength at an astonishing rate.

"More!"

The Blood Lord's sudden cry sent a shiver down Cheongpung's spine.

Because his voice was so much clearer now?

No.

It was the majestic internal energy carried in that cry—something Cheongpung hadn't been able to feel just moments ago.

No!

With that silent scream, Cheongpung thrust his sword forward with all his strength.

Sh-sh-sh-shhk!

Force brighter than ever slashed through the air.

The fanatics blocking his way, endlessly chanting their eight-character incantation, were cut to pieces and scattered.

A breakthrough aimed at a single point.

Jeong Hogun and the Embroidered Uniform Guards under his command, now among the defenders, charged in behind him.

"Wipe out the rebels!"

"Long live His Majesty the Emperor!"

They were the Great Nation's finest troops in every sense, each a martial artist of at least Supreme First Rate, with others at Peak.

They had cast aside the golden armor and helmets bestowed by the Son of Heaven, but their pride and their vows still shone. Every sword point drove in the same direction.

Toward the Blood Lord.

Fwoooosh! Boom!

A deafening crash sent a thick spray of blood surging through the air.

A narrow gap began to open among the countless fanatics, whose ranks had seemed like an unbreakable iron wall.

Slice! Thud-thud-thud!

Even with Temporary Strength Pills, they could not close the gap in martial enlightenment.

Dozens of Huashan's finest techniques poured from Cheongpung's blade, while the Embroidered Uniform Guards, led by Jeong Hogun, drove into the fanatics' formation like an awl.

Before another enemy could fill the gap.

So they could get one step closer, one moment sooner, to the Blood Lord.

At this rate, we can do it.

No—they had to do it.

They all thought so, and they were all prepared to die.

The Kunlun Sect Daoist who, even with a sword buried in his chest, used his last strength to wrap his arms around a fanatic.

The young, nameless soldier behind him, squeezing his eyes shut as he thrust his spear.

The middle-aged Embroidered Uniform Guard, holding in the entrails spilling from his split abdomen as he advanced, clad in pride that shone brighter than his armor.

They all knew it instinctively.

If they let the chance Jin Taekyung had given them slip away, they might never bring that monster down.

If the West Gate fell, they would be slaughtered—and so would the hundreds of thousands of people sheltering in the Inner City.

Their unshakable, desperate resolve shot toward the wall of fanaticism like the spear of someone kneeling behind them.

"Now!"

At Cheongpung's shout, every ally who had pushed deep into enemy lines squeezed out their remaining strength and lunged forward.

It might be their final charge. None of them would regret it.

Crack-crack-crack!

Fountains of blood burst into the air.

Cries of pain spilled from every direction, and the bodies of allies and enemies alike tangled together as they crumpled.

But it was enough.

Countless fanatics still surrounded them. Right now, though, Cheongpung had only one target.

Crunch. Crunch.

The monster was chewing something Cheongpung couldn't identify—and didn't want to. It suddenly turned to look at him.

It had two arms and two legs like a human, but could no longer be called one. In its red hand hung a corpse with its neck gone.

Dozens more bodies lay at its feet: fanatics dried out like mummies.

"Who are you?"

It looked and sounded genuinely curious.

Cheongpung didn't know why the monster couldn't remember him, but one thing was certain.

He still hasn't fully recovered.

Watching his reflection in those blood-red pupils, Cheongpung spat out his answer, his voice more hostile than ever.

"You don't deserve to hear my name."

And at that moment—

Flash.

Cheongpung's hand moved faster than sound. Purple light burst from his fingertips.

Slice!

Skin split, and blood flew.

The Blood Lord stared at Cheongpung in bewilderment, then blinked as he noticed the deep gash across his chest.

"Ah, ah…?"

With the pain, forgotten memories began to rise slowly to the surface.

And with them came anger.

"You…"

He reached out as though in a trance.

But before he could recover his memories, Cheongpung was already moving without hesitation.

Slice, slice, slice!

They moved at a speed like streaks of light, their bodies tangling and crossing. Each time they did, blood sprayed into the air.

The Blood Lord's blood.

Drip-drip-drip.

Watching his own blood spatter across the ground, the Blood Lord's eyes widened.

"…No."

It wasn't the pain.

Thirst.

The more blood he lost, the tighter that terrible thirst—briefly quenched—closed around him again.

Sh-sh-sh-shhk!

Even as sword strikes rained down like a storm, the Blood Lord looked around, his thirst growing stronger.

I need it. Blood. I need more.

But Cheongpung was pouring his last strength into the attack, giving him no time to quench it.

Crack! Crunch!

Blood flowed everywhere as the battle went on, but it wasn't nearly enough. It could only close the wounds appearing across his body, one after another.

But he had remembered something else he'd briefly forgotten.

Other beings that could quench his thirst.

Right. That's right.

The Blood Lord grinned, unable to contain his delight.

He raised both hands toward the sky and cried out eagerly.

"Come! Hurry!"

At that instant—

Whoosh!

The purple Force Cheongpung had sent flying grazed the Blood Lord's arm as he paused for an instant.

No—it cut through both arms.

Slice!

Both arms flew high into the air. Pain and thirst surged through him at once.

But even after losing the arms he had barely regenerated, the Blood Lord kept smiling.

He knew what the countless shadows plunging down toward him would do. They blocked even the heavy rain pouring over his head, turning an already dark sky utterly black.

They would quench his thirst.

Kiiieeet!

At the bloodcurdling sound that suddenly rang out from the air, Cheongpung instinctively looked up.

He saw them.

No. Everyone saw it clearly.

Countless flying beasts—too many to count—plunged toward the battlefield, their blood-red eyes flashing.

And at the center of them all, at the very end, was one being.

Flap-flap-flap!

A wave of monstrous creatures no one could block or evade.

Beyond the thunder of countless wings beating as they poured down and covered the space, the voice of the monster who had finally regained all his strength and memories pierced Cheongpung's ears.

"I remember your name."

"…!"

"And the debt I owe that bastard Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint."

At that moment—

Crack-crack-crack!

Flesh and bone tore with a sickening sound, and sticky blood stained Cheongpung's vision red.

Chapter 1110

It all began and ended in an instant.

“I remember. Your name.”

The low voice of the monster that had absorbed the life force of countless fiends raining down from the sky rang across the battlefield.

“And the debt I owe that bastard Mae Jonghak, the Sword Saint.”

At last, the monster—the Blood Lord—had awakened with all his strength and memories restored. His red eyes flashed.

Then a blood-red flash, brighter even than the light in his eyes, shot through the air.

Whoosh!

Cheongpung had to dodge. If it hit him, he would die.

But he had already spent all his strength. He could only watch helplessly as the Blood Lord’s palm struck the air like lightning, sending a blood-red palm strike hurtling toward him.

Someone else moved, though—guided by careful judgment honed through countless experiences and by an instant’s instinct.

Crunch!

A terrible tearing sound sent a chill down Cheongpung’s spine. Flesh and bone ripped away all at once, and the blood within burst out.

Splatter. Drip-drip.

Hot, sticky blood washed over his face. Cheongpung blinked, dazed.

Not from unbearable pain, or because he’d seen death looming before him.

Through his blood-red vision, he saw a man looking down at him. Somehow, Cheongpung had ended up sprawled on his side.

“Get… up. Quickly.”

Cough.

The man swallowed the blood that surged up whenever he opened his mouth and spoke again, his voice strained but calm. It was hard to believe the palm strike had torn off his arm all the way to the shoulder.

“Leave now. Before it’s too late.”

“B-but—”

Cheongpung’s mind had gone blank at this unexpected turn. He was just starting to stammer out a reply when—

“You fool!”

The fierce shout burst out without warning. Then a growl like a beast’s came from between the man’s bloodied lips.

“Do you still not understand? Can you still not see?”

Blood spilled with every word he ground out. Even so, he did not stop.

Something mattered more to him than the pain threatening to overwhelm his mind. More even than the death he knew was coming.

“None of this is for you! It’s to save everyone—to save the whole world!”

The man roared like a great tiger. He pointed to the Blood Lord, who was approaching even now amid scattering flashes of blood-red light, and to the people throwing themselves at that unprecedented monster without a moment’s hesitation.

BOOM!

Crack! Splaaash!

Deafening crashes shook the battlefield. Fountains of blood erupted without pause, blotting out the rain.

Cheongpung stared at the horrific hellscape of slaughter. At last, he gritted his teeth and stood.

Grind.

A dull pain, and the taste of blood filled his mouth.

But that was nothing compared to what those people were suffering as they were torn apart and broken, even now.

“I’ll… thank you later.”

What more was there to say?

The man smiled faintly and nodded. Watching Cheongpung walk away, he murmured as if to himself, “Please look after him. The Marquis of Shangshan.”

That was all. There would be no later for him, and he knew it.

Step.

His footstep felt unusually heavy as he turned. He fixed a calm gaze on the monster approaching through the dense mist of blood and spoke.

“You who dared to plot rebellion and throw the world into chaos: state your identity and surrender peacefully.”

“Criminal? Surrender?”

The Blood Lord’s mouth twisted into a smile. It held mockery—and the anger of a predator whose prey had slipped away before his eyes.

“There are a lot of you idiots who’ve got a death wish.”

Shhhhh.

In a matter of moments, the blood-red beams that had swallowed hundreds of lives rose in strands from the Blood Lord’s entire body.

“You should have run. It would only have bought you a little time, but at least you might have had a chance to look back on your life.”

The man gripped the great sword in the one hand he had left and answered.

“I don’t need that chance. I’m not like you.”

And he truly wasn’t.

Not everything he had done in his life had been perfectly just. But he had lived it with true loyalty. He had never blindly submitted to orders, nor had he wavered when powerful men dangled tempting offers before him.

He had proved himself, and in doing so earned the right to stand here—just as the others forming a square around him had, though they looked ready to collapse.

“Let me ask you all: what is our duty?”

At the sudden question from their commander, the roughly three hundred surviving Embroidered Uniform Guards answered as one.

“To protect the Imperial House with an unshakable oath and unwavering loyalty!”

Some voices were young, others old.

The familiar faces of friends and comrades who had shared their lives with them—less than half remained.

Each remembered the oath they had etched into their hearts the day they first received shining golden armor.

“Then what is our obligation?”

They were exhausted in body and mind. Even raising their voices was a struggle now.

That was why they drew on every last bit of strength to answer: so the fear creeping into their hearts would not rule them, and so their oath would not fade even in death.

“To protect all the people—and beyond them, the whole world!”

“…!”

Their cry shook the air. The sneer on the Blood Lord’s lips began to fade.

Vroooom.

The great sword in the man’s hand trembled and shone with a clear light.

Force. Magnificent and radiant, it had long seemed to him a realm he could never reach.

Did enlightenment finally come when I let go of everything? Or… is Heaven telling me to fight back however I can?

The question crossed his mind, and he let out a quiet laugh.

He didn’t know where this sudden power had come from. It no longer mattered. He knew what he had to do, and that was enough.

“As a Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, carrying out His Majesty the Emperor’s exalted will, I give you your orders!”

The man—Jeong Hogun—swallowed the blood surging up his throat and shouted. He leveled his Force, burning like a final rally, at the enemies who had surrounded them and the monster at their center.

“Behead the rebels!”

At that moment—

“Loyalty!”

Their military salute rang out with more force and desperation than ever. Jeong Hogun and the roughly three hundred Embroidered Uniform Guards charged with a roar that caught in their throats.

Straight toward the death looming before them.

Their bodies would perish, but what they did at the end would remain.

They were magnificent.

Whoosh.

And it was glorious.

CRUNCH!

A massive blood-red flash erupted without warning, staining everything around them. Within it, they fell.

My vision was blurry.

Pains large and small jabbed through my body like sharp awls. Every sound reaching my ears seemed distant, like an echo from beyond a mountain ridge.

Ah.

A question suddenly occurred to me.

Where was I? Who was I? And why were my eyelids so heavy?

It was strange. I could’ve sworn I remembered everything just a moment ago.

I just want to sleep. Peacefully.

I couldn’t think of anything else. If I could just fall asleep, I felt I would be completely at peace.

A desperate longing to rest somewhere without pain or worry was the only thing ruling my body.

—Rest, huh? That doesn’t sound so bad.

An unfamiliar voice echoed in my mind, but I wasn’t even curious who it belonged to. Maybe I was hearing things as I drifted in and out. Maybe another part of me agreed.

What did it matter, as long as I could fall asleep in peace?

Right? There’s nothing wrong with taking a little rest.

The voice answered my question.

—If you put it that way… I’d have to say there are plenty of reasons it could be a problem.

A problem?

—You know why better than I do.

What?

I was bewildered. I didn't even remember who I was. How could I know why?

The voice spoke again.

—You can't feel it, can you? Even now, you're struggling with everything you have to wake up.

That couldn't be right. That was nonsense from some clueless idiot.

My vision was blurred and spinning, and pain was gnawing at every part of me. Who wouldn't want to rest like this? I wanted so badly to fall asleep.

—Are you sure?

Of course.

Or… I thought so.

—Then how are you still conscious? All you have to do is close your eyes and give in to instinct. Everything will be peaceful.

That's…

—Don't tell me you've forgotten how to fall asleep.

I had no answer.

Confusion had crept in and begun to push the drowsiness aside, though I hadn't even noticed. All I could do was turn a question over in my mind.

Why? Why am I fighting so hard to hold on?

This time, the voice gave me no answer.

Instead, fragments of memory fell one by one onto the once-calm surface of my consciousness. And from somewhere deep within me, an unfamiliar current of qi began to rise.

Whooosh.

It felt as though a wind were blowing. Clear and refreshing, it pressed down on the pain that had tormented me and rekindled the dying embers of my memory.

My name. Countless faces and voices. As my senses sharpened, the strong smell of blood and someone's shout reached me too.

…!

…!!

My vision slowly cleared, and the echo drew closer.

Amid it all, I finally remembered why I had wanted so badly to rest—and why, despite that, I had refused to let go of consciousness.

I… I…

As my mind awoke, the pain returned with it.

Was this what it felt like to fall into a pit of fire? To have my body torn into thousands of pieces?

I didn’t know. I couldn’t know.

But I knew one thing: I still had so much left to protect.

—As always, a good decision.

At the moment the unknown voice whispered its last words in my mind—

Whoooosh.

The wind sweeping through my body became a wave of qi carrying the fragrance of flowers. It washed over me.

No—it lifted my dying body and mind back to their feet.

And at last, I heard a familiar voice.

“…Benefactor! Benefactor!”

A frantic cry. A face drenched in tears.

I woke with a gasp, and Cheongpung’s voice thundered in my ears.

“The West Gate—the West Gate…!”

The reality I had barely returned to was still cruel.

Chapter 1111

Boom, boom, ba-boom!

There was nothing strange about hearing a war drum in the middle of a battle.

The drum on the highest watchtower was practically another command post, keeping watch over the walls on all sides.

But its beat had never sounded so urgent, so perilous. Something in it gripped the hearts of everyone who heard it.

Slice!

A streak of light shot across the foot of the wall like a bolt of lightning.

Dozens of fanatics charging in while scattering Sword Energy were cut to pieces and sent flying. Yet the man responsible for this display of divine might wore a rigid expression.

“This is…”

His words trailed off. The Slaughter Saint, who had been fighting enemies right beneath the wall, turned on instinct—not toward the Inner City, where the drum was sounding, but toward the west, where a muffled roar reached him from far away.

Even he didn’t know exactly why.

All he knew was that his instincts, honed by countless experiences, and the immense surge of power that had boiled over from the west moments ago were stirring every one of his senses.

For an instant, even the streaks of light plunging down from above slipped from his mind.

Shreeeeeeek!

Countless ice spikes rained down, freezing the air around them.

The Slaughter Saint felt the chill bearing down on him, but he didn’t take his eyes off the west.

Someone he could trust stood behind him.

Whoosh!

The wall lit up. A beam of light shot from someone’s fingertips and swallowed hundreds of ice spikes whole.

KABOOOOOM!

A blinding flash erupted with a thunderous crash.

Before the shockwaves of the collision had fully faded, the Bow Saint’s clear Sound Transmission rang in the Slaughter Saint’s ears.

—The West Gate has fallen.

“…!”

The Slaughter Saint swallowed the groan rising in his throat.

The ominous premonition he'd feared had come true. But that left him even less time to lament. With one of the pillars holding their already fragile balance now completely broken, everything was in danger.

—Then the allies defending the West Gate…

—More than half are casualties, according to the numbers confirmed so far. They say the Embroidered Uniform Guard bought us at least a little time by fighting to the death.

Half.

It was no wonder the Slaughter Saint bit his lip at that staggering number.

More than ten thousand defenders had been stationed at the West Gate. And half of them had vanished—in barely half an hour after the battle began in earnest.

—What happened to the survivors?

—Some retreated to the Inner City. Others seem to still be holding off the enemy from the rear.

—Then, could it be…

A grim thought crossed his mind, and he fell silent. The Bow Saint's quiet Sound Transmission continued.

—Cheongpung and Jin Taekyung. The two of them retreated to the Inner City.

—…They were lucky.

The Slaughter Saint held back a sigh of relief.

After so many had already been lost, it wouldn't be right to focus only on the survival of those two just because he had ties to them.

But the Bow Saint had more to tell him.

—If those two are alive, we still have a chance. While they defend the Inner City, we can strike back as hard as—

—Even that won't be easy. Not in their current condition.

—What… do you mean?

—Jin Taekyung is badly injured, I'm told. Cheongpung isn't in good shape, either.

—…!

The Slaughter Saint's eyes widened.

He stopped moving without realizing it. A blade swung at his shoulder.

Slice!

The strike was fast and powerful. He twisted aside at the last moment, but the Sword Energy carried by the blade grazed him and cut his skin.

Of course, even the man lucky enough to land that remarkable hit couldn't escape death.

Thud!

A dagger flew from the Slaughter Saint's fingertips and buried itself between the enemy's brows. At the same time, his figure blurred like a ghost and shot up the wall.

Whoosh, slice!

In the blink of an eye, he stood atop the wall, cutting down enemies climbing by chains and ladders as his lips moved.

—How bad?

The Bow Saint kept firing arrows of Force at the enemy as she answered.

—They can't say whether he'll live.

—…Blood Lord. We underestimated that bastard.

A low groan escaped the Slaughter Saint.

He hadn't been comfortable leaving the West Gate to Jin Taekyung from the start. He'd only been persuaded by the same argument they had used with Jeok Cheongang.

—We shouldn't have left him there after all.

—It wouldn't have changed anything, as long as the Blood Lord's intentions stayed the same.

—I have to go to the Inner City. Hold this gate until then.

There was no time to waste.

If Jin Taekyung's life hung by a thread, the Slaughter Saint was the only one who could pull him back from death.

With a heavy heart, he turned to leave.

Or tried to.

Until a clear voice reached his ears.

"Is that really the best choice?"

"…What do you mean?"

"Without you, Slaughter Saint, we can't hold this gate. I certainly can't hold it alone."

The Slaughter Saint had no answer.

Of course he knew how dangerous their position was here, at the South Gate.

Even apart from the Grand Sorceress, they faced four Black Ghosts. The mages supporting them were still hurling spells at the wall while granting the fanatics greater strength and speed.

That was why he'd been forced to leave his assigned post at the East Gate and join the defense of the South Gate after only fifteen minutes.

But…

"Are you saying we should just let him—Jin Taekyung—die?"

The Bow Saint met his disbelieving gaze. When she spoke, her voice was graver than he had ever heard it.

“We may have no choice. If that is the death fate has given him.”

“You…!”

“That boy needs the Divine Physician. I know. But right now, all of us need the Slaughter Saint.”

“…!”

“So which choice is best?”

The Slaughter Saint’s eyelids trembled.

Her question pierced his heart like an awl, and he knew the answer better than anyone.

Yet the woman standing before him felt like a stranger.

Why?

He knew why the Bow Saint had reappeared after vanishing for so long. He’d heard how she had followed a letter left by the Martial God, spending years searching for the one called the “chosen one.”

That made her words and actions now all the harder to understand.

Why wasn’t she trying to save the chosen one—or rather, Jin Taekyung?

There was something in her eyes and voice that he couldn’t begin to fathom. It was more than simple faith that Taekyung would survive.

Bow Saint, what exactly are you hiding?

He forced down the question on the tip of his tongue, along with the doubts racing through his mind.

The enemy’s assault was growing fiercer, as though it would not allow him even a moment to think.

Fwoooosh.

A massive sphere of flame suddenly turned the sky red, blotting out the wind and rain.

It hurtled toward them with terrifying force. The Slaughter Saint leaped from the wall to meet it without hesitation.

Whoosh!

A streak of light cut through the air along the path traced by his fingertips. A rift opened, followed by an explosion.

KABOOOOOM!

The ball of fire shattered into hundreds of pieces and scattered in every direction. The Slaughter Saint landed where he had started and fixed a profound gaze on the Bow Saint.

“Is that answer enough?”

Perhaps she saw the change in his eyes. A bitter smile crossed her lips.

“It does.”

Leaving her behind, the Slaughter Saint silently turned to face the enemies, who had dyed the land outside the wall pitch-black.

More precisely, he looked toward the one who had just displayed magic of a power beyond anything they'd seen so far.

The Grand Sorceress.

The face of another ringleader, who had finally stepped forward, burned itself onto the Slaughter Saint's eyes. Four Black Ghosts stood around her like guards.

Then—

Rumble…

A chilling vibration rose from deep beneath the earth. The Slaughter Saint turned his head in one direction.

He thought of the one person who cherished Jin Taekyung more than anyone in the world—the one person who would rush into any danger for him.

You're the only one left now. I'm counting on you, Fire King.

Just as the Slaughter Saint murmured those words in his heart—

Rrrrrumble!

The ground within a radius of roughly a hundred jang[3837] around the South Gate heaved its vast, heavy body upward.

A man's voice rang out across the battlefield.

"Shake it."

Earthquake.

KABOOOOOM!

Rumble!

The violent tremor began in the south and spread in every direction. Those who felt it reacted in different ways.

"A-an earthquake!"

Some thought of a disaster no human strength could stop and were seized by fear.

"Don't falter! What is there left to fear?"

Others, already prepared to die, fought the enemy without giving an inch.

"Damn bitch. She hasn't noticed already, has she?"

And one man, recognizing the power, fired blood-red flashes at the moths foolish enough to block his path to the Inner City.

He needed to take one man's life quickly—and for good—before anything else could get in his way.

[3837] A jang is a traditional Korean measure of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

But that man—the Blood Lord—didn't know what was happening several hundred jang[3838] away at the North Gate.

A massacre far beyond anything he had expected.

"A-a demon…"

Cough.

Blood mixed with bits of entrails spilled from the old monk's lips.

His bright yellow robe was soaked through, its original color nowhere to be seen. Blackened corpses lay scattered in every direction.

None of them knew how many people had met such a terrible end.

Not even the man who had created this hellscape.

There was only one thing he knew for certain.

Crack.

The middle-aged monk whose neck he had just broken in his grasp was the last survivor of the Twelve Secret Monks, renowned as Tibet's finest.

"Now you're the only one left."

The old monk standing rigid as a statue was the only obstacle still in his way.

"…!"

The Dalai Lama's eyes were wide open, his pupils trembling.

Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, took a weary step toward him.

He thought of his Disciple, who must be in danger by now.

He reminded himself of his resolve.

"Let's finish this quickly. He's waiting."

Fwoosh.

A white flame spread across his fatigue-dimmed pupils.

[3838] A jang is a traditional Korean measure of length, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Chapter 1112

Is this a dream?

The Dalai Lama wondered.

At the same time, he wished more desperately than ever that it was. If this was all a terrible nightmare, he wanted to wake from it as soon as possible—and never have another like it.

But—

Grind.

The pain in the lip he'd bitten without realizing it, the stench of blood in his nostrils, and the acrid smoke all around him whispered the same truth.

That this utterly horrific, unbelievable scene was real.

"Truly… a fiend if ever there was one."

The Dalai Lama's words came out like a groan.

The man reflected in the old monk's eyes looked like a fiend torn from an ancient scripture. He had burned to death the Twelve Secret Monks—his Disciples and fellow martial brothers—and even the two Black Ghosts who had been such dependable reinforcements.

"Fire King Jeok Cheongang."

His voice trembled with anger and fear.

The fiend striding toward him, by contrast, showed no hint of hesitation.

Whoosh.

Embers scattered. The air grew hot.

The Dalai Lama's eyes flew wide as Jeok Cheongang closed more than ten jang[3839] in an instant and rushed straight at him, white flames flickering at his fingertips.

BOOM!

Compressed air exploded, and the flames swallowed wind and rain.

KABOOOOOM!

Was this what a wave of fire looked like?

Watching the searing heat sweep through the place where he had stood moments ago, the Dalai Lama felt a chill run down his spine.

"Flame Divine Palm…!"

There was no way he could mistake it.

It was the fiend's martial art, recorded by his ancestors and passed down for more than two hundred years—the very technique that had sent all twelve Secret Monks, including two Supreme Peak masters, to their deaths.

"You recognize it? Did word of this old man reach all the way to that backwater?"

[3839] A jang is ten Korean cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30 m (99 ft).

Whoosh!

Jeok Cheongang's low voice sounded above him, accompanied by the rush of air. Emerging through the acrid smoke, he drove a tightly clenched fist down toward the crown of the Dalai Lama's head.

The Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist—the technique that had reduced the two Black Ghosts to ash before the Twelve Secret Monks met their end.

KABOOM!

The ground shook. A pillar of fire shot upward, and the rolling heat burned skin at a mere brush.

Sizzle.

It felt like a branding iron pressed to his flesh.

Yet the Dalai Lama dodged by a hair once more and thrust both palms forward with all his strength.

Crack!

Their hands met. The immense qi within them tangled and collided without pause.

But unlike a moment ago, the fear was gradually fading from the Dalai Lama's eyes as he clashed head-on with Jeok Cheongang.

He's strong, but that's all.

He could feel it clearly through their joined hands. The qi of the man who had displayed such unbelievable power mere moments ago was wavering sharply.

It was the truth his fear had briefly hidden from him—and the truth Jeok Cheongang had wanted to conceal.

Nothing comes without a price.

Perfected Being Hyeoncheon of the Kongtong Sect, who had helped Jeok Cheongang defend the North Gate, was already down with severe internal injuries after a battle involving no fewer than five Supreme Peak masters.

Even Jeok Cheongang could not have come through it unscathed. Realizing this at last, the Dalai Lama fixed a cold gaze on the enemy before him. His anger, briefly driven back by fear, returned.

"You're gravely mistaken."

"What?"

"We didn't learn of you through you, Fire King Jeok Cheongang. We learned of you through your predecessor—the one who should have fallen into the Eight Hot Hells[3840] long ago."

The Dalai Lama bit off each syllable.

"Our Potala Palace never forgot. No—we came to a point where we could never forget."

[3840] In Buddhist cosmology, the Eight Hot Hells are realms of progressively harsher suffering.

It had all begun more than two hundred years ago, on the day a wild-haired stranger in blood-red rags set foot in Tibet.

For the Potala Palace, it was the deepest, most devastating wound—and a history of humiliation that could never be washed away.

Bring in that suspicious foreigner staying at an inn in Chamdo immediately. I will personally interrogate him to find out who he is, where he came from, and why he's here.

The Dalai Lama who gave that order could never have guessed what would follow.

The Potala Palace considered its influence in Tibet comparable to that of the Demonic Cult. Surely even an ignorant foreigner would not dare defy them.

Nor could he have imagined that the foreigner would leave the twenty-odd martial monks sent to capture him half-crippled, then storm the palace himself, eyes rolled back in his head.

Who are you? Which bald bastard ordered you to smash the first meal this old man has seen in three days?

Perhaps that had been their last chance.

They could have apologized for the martial monks' rather rough attempt to approach him. They could have prepared enough meat and liquor to make the table sag, to make up for interrupting his long-awaited meal. Then, once the mood had warmed like an oven stuffed with firewood, they could have talked.

If only they had done that.

But as the records attest, events took no such heartwarming turn.

Twenty martial monks had already been left half-crippled for overturning his table and trying to use their weapons. And the Potala Palace, which strictly observed its principles of non-killing and abstinence, had neither liquor nor meat on hand to calm him.

When the furious stranger stormed into the main palace that day, he found no table sagging beneath meat and liquor. Instead, he found two hundred martial monks who could break a person's limbs with their bare hands.

Among them were the Dalai Lama of that era, acknowledged by all as Tibet's greatest master, and four of the Twelve Secret Monks who served at his side.

You seem to be a fairly well-known martial artist from the Central Plains… Surrender peacefully now, and I'll settle this with twenty years of wall-gazing meditation. What do you say, donor?

The stranger's answer was firm.

That's a terrible deal. I refuse.

Good grief. You're making this difficult.

You bald monks made this what it is. This old man hasn't done a damn thing wrong. At least, not yet.

…Not yet?

Ahem. Anyway, I was planning to rest for a while and leave quietly. This time, at least.

…This time, at least?

I didn't like it when bald monks I'd never seen before came barging in out of nowhere. But if you'd waited quietly in a corner until I finished eating, I would've gone along with it. Hell, if you hadn't tried to force me down, none of this would've happened.

I can't say you're entirely wrong. Still, even allowing for my Disciples' slight discourtesy, your response was excessive.

They overturned my precious meal and even tried to use weapons. You call that a slight discourtesy?

Faced with that pointed question, the Dalai Lama chose silence over admitting the truth. The stranger studied him—the man already seemed more martial artist than monk—and sighed deeply.

Hearing you say that, I deeply regret it.

Oh? Truly?

Of course. I swear it to Heaven and Earth.

The stranger's next words sealed everyone's fate.

I should've crippled them completely instead of leaving them half-crippled.

…You're a fiend to the bone. What can be done now? It's come to this. Please, don't hold it against us. May you find peace in your next life.

And so, the killing began.

A storm of blood swept through, driven by one side alone.

A dreadful storm of blood that would be remembered for more than two hundred years, and would still be remembered a thousand years later, as long as the Potala Palace endured.

"One hundred died there that day. Another hundred were crippled."

Recalling his sect's humiliation, the Dalai Lama spoke in a harsh, grating voice. His gaze on Jeok Cheongang was colder than ever, and the anger in his steady voice had swallowed his fear.

"The Dalai Lama of that time died too."

The four Twelve Secret Monks who had been there with him barely survived, but like the martial monks who lived through it, they were never able to use martial arts again.

"It was a terrible humiliation. Something that should never have happened—something we had thought impossible."

All of it had taken barely half a day. The Potala Palace's martial monks, scattered across Tibet to maintain order, rushed back to the main palace with all their might.

There, at last, they saw it.

The once-imposing palace lay in ruins. Scrawled across a charred pillar that had been wrenched from the ground was a single line:

> The Jade Emperor[3841] says: Even a dog should be left alone while it eats.

Beneath that saying of highly dubious origin, the writer had carefully inscribed his credentials in a style every bit as long and grandiose.

“Fifth Sect Leader of the great Fire Gate Clan. Ghost Flame Fist Songhak.”

The Dalai Lama ground out the accursed name that had been passed down to this day.

“If we’d captured him then, none of this would be happening today.”

But the martial monks had not captured Ghost Flame Fist Songhak and sent him to meet Yama.[3842]

After branding the Potala Palace with an indelible humiliation, he had melted through the net over heaven and earth cast by Tibet’s Murim and headed straight for the Central Plains.

Before that, he had fled the Mad Wind Society of the great desert—the reason he had entered Tibet at all. Their pursuit had kept him from eating for three days, a particular hardship for the man who valued his meals more than any other Sect Leader in the Fire Gate Clan’s history.

Songhak returned to the clan’s home on Mount Jiuhua in high spirits and wrote a brief account of his thrilling exploits.

> I have always held the Fourth Ancestor, the Third Sect Leader, in the deepest respect. Following in his footsteps, I traveled the world and the Outer Murim.
>
> As it happened, I fought the Mad Wind Society of the great desert beyond the scorching sands and uprooted the Potala Palace’s very pillars.
>
> At this, all the men and horses of Tibet grew enraged and pursued me.
>
> But who am I?
>
> I am Ghost Flame Fist Songhak, Fifth Sect Leader of the great Fire Gate Clan. Without so much as a hair harmed, I… avoided them and returned safely to the Central Plains.

Of course, Ghost Flame Fist Songhak had no idea that more than two hundred years later, a distant descendant would find this proud record and mutter that he was a madman.

[3841] The Jade Emperor is a heavenly ruler in Daoist tradition.

[3842] Yama is the ruler of the underworld in Buddhist tradition.

Nor did he know the Potala Palace would nurse its grudge for so long.

In truth, he had not cared in the slightest.

“I learned later that before all that, he’d slaughtered more than five hundred of the Mad Wind Society’s mounted bandits in the desert.”

The Mad Wind Society had tried to steal Songhak’s horse and lost most of its leadership instead. Unable to recover from the damage, it eventually vanished into history.

The Potala Palace, however, did not.

With no rival in Tibetan Murim, its members quietly vowed revenge.

Some scholarly monks urged forgiveness and mercy to prevent further bloodshed, but their voices could not overcome the fury of the martial monks, who were closer to martial artists than to monks.

And so the Potala Palace gradually changed.

Its members began spending more time with martial arts manuals than with scriptures. They accepted only children with exceptional aptitude and greatly expanded their ranks of martial monks.

“We swore that even if Ghost Flame Fist died and turned to dust before we could avenge that day, we would end the line of those fiends with our own hands.”

By the time the land had changed nearly ten times over, the Potala Palace had grown into a fighting force far stronger than it had ever been. Even its members believed the time for revenge had come.

But the man who had been chosen as the new Dalai Lama in childhood, according to Potala Palace tradition, was not satisfied. That had been about a hundred years ago.

“We had grown stronger, certainly. But it was still nowhere near enough. To take our revenge ourselves, we would have to face the entire Central Plains.”

Just as Songhak had been shunned as a foreigner the moment he set foot in Tibet, the Potala Palace would be nothing but an outsider in the Central Plains. A dangerous outsider, at that—one with enough power to unleash a storm of bloodshed.

The Fire Gate Clan might have spent years stirring up trouble and accumulating gratitude and grudges, but the martial artists of the Central Plains would never seek out the Fire Gate Clan and hand it over to dangerous outsiders from the west for revenge.

“In the end, we needed greater strength. Or… an ally who would join us against the Central Plains.”

Crack.

The force in the Dalai Lama’s hands suddenly surged, pushing Jeok Cheongang’s hands back little by little.

The balance between them was finally breaking.

“The Demonic Cult was truly foolish. The arrogant Heavenly Demon mocked us for being weak. That was his greatest mistake.”

“The Great Faction War… Hah. I thought you were just a bald monk consumed by an old grudge with no claim to justice. Now I can’t even call you a monk.”

Jeok Cheongang forced down the blood rising in his throat and gave the Dalai Lama a scornful look.

“How ridiculous. Don’t you think?”

“What?”

“Look at yourself. You’ve joined hands with fiends worse than the Demonic Cult, and you dare call anyone else a fiend?”

“…!”

The Dalai Lama flinched.

Jeok Cheongang’s sudden rebuke carried a terrifying aura. In the flames blazing within Jeok’s eyes, the Dalai Lama finally saw what he had become.

Red. His eyes were red.

Their light had taken on the color of the pool of blood at his feet.

Slowly, but steadily.

“All for that pathetic power, you even broke a taboo.”

“N-no. I…!”

His eyes and voice trembled.

But nothing he said could undo the truth of the past.

He had needed to grow stronger. Somehow, he had needed more and more power.

The countless pills and martial arts Dark Heaven offered had made that possible.

No—more precisely, that new power, infused with demonic energy, had made it possible.

Jeok Cheongang gave a quiet laugh. The Dalai Lama had been confronted with a contradiction he had forgotten—or had tried desperately to ignore.

“If you’ve got nothing to say, shut your mouth. Even this old man, with a strong stomach, can’t stand the excuses coming off a fiend’s tongue.”

“You bastard! Shut your mouth!”

Fwoosh!

A vast wave of energy surged in every direction.

Using his blazing rage as kindling, the Dalai Lama finally wrung every last bit of power and potential from deep within himself and drove his full strength against the enemy before him.

Crack!

The balance had tipped decisively. Bones shifted, and the flames around Jeok Cheongang’s hands began to dim.

Then, through lips streaked with blood—a testament to his mounting injuries and exhaustion—Jeok Cheongang released a single azure dragon's roar.

"Hyeoncheon! Now!"

At that moment—

Shhhhh.

The world seemed to slow. The Dalai Lama tore his hands free of Jeok Cheongang's with all his strength and spun around, every hair on his body standing on end.

He remembered the man who had slipped from his thoughts: the Kongtong Sect Leader, whom he had believed unable to fight.

Far away, Perfected Being Hyeoncheon was leaning against the corpse of a huge elephant, drawing only the faintest breaths. The Dalai Lama froze.

No.

Crack!

The terrible heat that drove deep into his body did not allow him even that instant.

"…!"

His body shuddered as if lightning had pierced it.

Yet no blood spilled from him. Not a single scream escaped his lips. The flames had vaporized the blood that should have burst forth, and the pain was so overwhelming he forgot even to cry out.

But perhaps the worst pain of all was his enemy's low voice, sounding beside his ear.

"Fire King Jeok Cheongang says: Never harm a being who has something it must protect, even if that being is a beast."

Like the ancestor who had carved his own words into a Potala Palace pillar, Jeok Cheongang whispered in a faint but clear voice. His hand had pierced the Dalai Lama's back and burst through his chest. He clenched it tight.

"Especially if that being belongs to the Fire Gate Clan."

The Dalai Lama could not answer.

His senses cut off from the world, and darkness swallowed his sight.

"Go on ahead, fiend of Tibet. This old man still has something to protect."

Thud.

At last, his head slumped.

With his enemy's final words echoing like Yama's, the Dalai Lama's world closed around him.

Chapter 1113

Nothing can be gained without sacrifice.

That was even more true for those seeking victory through war—the most terrible form of violence—in an age of savagery that had thrown law and benevolence to the dogs.

But even knowing that cruel reality, there were some things one could never get used to.

Like realizing that someone who had been laughing and talking with you not long ago was gone.

"…So, that's how it ended."

After hearing what had happened immediately after he lost consciousness, Jin Taekyung quietly closed his eyes, muttering to himself.

Faces came to mind. So many people who, though he had known them only a short time, had looked at him with trust.

Along with them came the stony face and voice of someone whose presence had gradually become familiar.

"It doesn't matter who you are. The Embroidered Uniform Guard obeys only His Majesty the Emperor's command. If you stand in our way in defiance of his imperial decree, I'll kill you."

"Perhaps it's because you're a martial artist without even an identity tag, but your manners are atrocious."

"Thank you. For protecting us—for protecting the imperial family."

Fleeting moments brushed faintly past his eyes and ears.

And at the end of those memories was always the figure of someone who had pressed forward without wavering.

"Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, answers the command of the Marquis of Shangshan!"

Remembering the voice he would never hear again, Taekyung opened his eyes without a word and forced down something rising from deep in his chest.

The officer had been so stubbornly steadfast it was almost foolish. He had always been calm, and always stood tall.

Taekyung had lost consciousness before witnessing Jeong Hogun's final moments, but he was certain the man had faced them the same way.

Because that was who he was.

The Embroidered Uniform Guards who had served under Taekyung over the past three months must have been the same. So must the defenders at the West Gate, who had fought with their lives on the line.

They had all fought to protect others and died valiantly.

Taekyung would never forget that their sacrifice had allowed so many people, himself included, to survive.

Neither would the person beside him, head bowed and shedding tears.

"…I'm sorry, Benefactor. I wasn't good enough."

Cheongpung's eyes glistened, and his voice trembled.

Looking at Cheongpung as he blamed himself, Jin Taekyung spoke in a calm voice.

"You're right. We weren't good enough. Neither you nor I."

"No. You did everything you could. If only I'd been a little stronger…"

"Young Hero Cheongpung."

"Yes?"

"If only the Blood Lord—no, the Lord of Heaven—had never been born. That would've been nice, wouldn't it?"

"…!"

"If, maybe, what if… Get those stupid thoughts out of your head. Even if you're sorry to the dead, even if you hate yourself like crazy for surviving, bear it."

Grit.

Jin Taekyung slowly shifted his body, which had been propped against the Inner City wall. He clenched his jaw without meaning to, against the terrible pain that seemed to reach every cell in his body.

So were the fury and self-reproach he had been struggling to hold back since regaining consciousness. No matter how hard he suppressed them, they kept surging up from deep in his chest.

His legs suddenly went slack like a puppet with its strings cut.

He caught the wall but staggered, and Cheongpung hurriedly reached out to support him.

Or tried to.

Before Cheongpung's hand could touch him, Taekyung firmly shook his head.

"B-Benefactor."

Cheongpung watched, his eyes wavering, as Taekyung forced himself upright. Beads of sweat ran down Taekyung's forehead, and his face was deathly pale.

But what showed on the outside was not the whole story.

Cheongpung had poured his own internal energy into Taekyung to lend him strength. He knew better than anyone that the damage inside his body was even worse than it looked.

Some of the tears he had shed earlier had come from a terrible premonition: that he would be unable to stop Jin Taekyung from dying.

But—

Thump.

Taekyung did not stop. He did not give up.

Bearing the pain with everything he had and suppressing the emotions boiling like lava in his chest, he gripped the wall and stood again.

Slowly. Stubbornly.

Each second felt like ten years as he forced the words out.

“Think about why we survived. Why they had to give their lives to save us.”

They could not fall apart. They must not.

If they gave up now, it would all have been for nothing.

The sacrifice of those who had died opening a path of retreat.

The sacrifice of others who might be dying even now.

“Apologize to the dead and cry your eyes out after we’ve finished everything we have to do.”

He wasn’t speaking only to Cheongpung.

Jin Taekyung kept speaking resolutely to everyone around him. Their heads hung low, their faces marked by desperation or defeat. Exhausted in body and mind, they had briefly forgotten their duty.

“That’s the only way… we can show them the respect they deserve. It’s our duty.”

Step.

Taekyung finally took a step after forcing out those last words.

“…!”

“…!”

The air around them thrummed. An unseen surge rose together with a wave of heat.

One step.

He had taken only one step.

He was a pitiful sight, a young man so covered in blood that no one would have been surprised if he collapsed on the spot.

Yet simply watching him made their hearts pound.

The heavy sense of defeat that had gripped them began to lift, and something hot filled the space it left behind.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

A pulse began to spread like ripples across a still pond. No one knew who had started it, or where.

Outside the Inner City, the war drums beat faster and faster, announcing the approach of death. But that did not matter.

Not now. Not while they stood with him—a martial artist who had made his way through a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords, a marquis of the Great Nation, and, beyond that, a fellow subject living in this vast realm.

For a moment, they could forget.

And remember what they had forgotten.

KABOOM!

Even when a thunderous crash sounded in the distance and the war drums that had seemed destined to ring forever fell silent.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

Countless enemies came sweeping down the avenue toward the Inner City, their footsteps shaking the ground.

Clang-clang-clang!

Steel rang out, and desperate screams filled the air.

Thump-thump-thump-thump!

Still, the defenders stamped their feet with all their strength and struck their weapons against the ground, coaxing the embers of their battle cry back into flame.

They thought of the countless people huddled deep inside the Inner City, trembling.

Their eyes, alight with renewed fire, fixed on one man.

“Remember this, all of you.”

His voice had grown clear. They watched the silver-white spearhead rise slowly.

“Remember what we’ve stayed alive for.”

Shing.

He spat out the words, and the spearhead gave off a frost-sharp aura.

Whoosh.

Behind him, standing tall as an iron tower, strands of violet light rose and blazed brighter than torches, illuminating the darkness.

And beneath the energy of the Zaha Divine Technique spreading like the sunset at dusk, the corner of one person’s eye was no longer wet.

His voice, sunk deeper than ever, was the same.

“I’ll do it. I promise.”

The battle was not over yet.

Red. Everything was red.

At least, everything one man could see was awash in corpses and blood.

Slice!

How many lives vanished in the space of a single deep breath?

Heads flew here and there. Limbs were severed. Some people died slowly in agony.

[3843] A Daoist is a practitioner of Daoism, a Chinese philosophical and religious tradition.

They had once been Daoists[3843] in fluttering white robes, as refined as immortals; soldiers fed by the nation they served; martial artists and common people. Now it was impossible to tell them apart.

Covered in blood from head to toe, they had become part of the hellscape painted across Xining's main road.

The man who had drawn its first stroke—and would put the final mark on it—watched the slaughter unfold before him.

What fools.

He couldn't understand it.

What were they fighting for?

An Emperor whose bloodline alone had qualified him to rule?

Or that embarrassing notion they called "justice," which did not even have a form?

Ridiculous.

Most of them had probably never seen the Emperor's face. And the justice the martial artists of the Central Plains would die for was nothing more than something they had made up within their own little circle.

But the Lord of Heaven was different. He alone was different.

His power and overwhelming presence made the Blood Lord tremble simply by being near him.

In a world where might made right, what ruler could be more fitting?

This loyal servant will fulfill your wish.

The Blood Lord shot forward with a vow he could not tell whether he was making to the Lord of Heaven or to himself.

Whoosh!

A chillingly low whistle cut through the air. A moment later, the front line of defenders blocking the road to the Inner City crumpled, though they had not given up the fight.

A hundred bodies fell like puppets with their strings cut. Fountains of dark blood shot high above them.

Splatter!

Blood rained in every direction.

Among the defenders who witnessed the unbelievable sight, a trembling voice spoke.

"A-a monster…"

"Yes. I suppose that's what I look like to you."

The Blood Lord smiled and reached out.

BOOM!

A flash of blood-red light swelled and exploded. The blast swallowed the screams, scattering torn flesh and bone.

“But after he takes the world, who will call me a monster?”

It was a world where might made right.

The day was not far off when a blood-mad monster would be hailed as a divine general sent by Heaven.

Though he had failed to take the life of one man whose death was necessary for that great undertaking—

“Open the way, you worthless moths.”

Slice! Stab-stab-stab!

To the Blood Lord, it was all only a matter of time.

The Inner City was close enough to see now. As long as fierce fighting continued at the other three walls, no one could stand in his way.

Grand Sorceress, you bitch, stay out of this. Even I don’t want to kill a servant girl the Lord of Heaven favors with my own hands.

The Blood Lord was about to resume the slaughter when—

Whoosh! BOOM!

A sharp, dazzling flash blocked the steps of the monster who had seemed impossible to stop.

Chapter 1114

The beam of light that crossed the space between them in an instant was dazzling—and devastating.

Even barehanded, the Blood Lord had been slaughtering the defenders without mercy. Now the flash forced him to draw the beloved blade that had rested quietly at his waist.

BOOM!

A deafening crash—and blood sprayed in every direction.

But this time, it wasn't the defenders' blood. It belonged to the fanatics who followed him.

"C-cough. Blood Lord…"

Was the man lucky or unlucky?

Dozens of his comrades had been caught in the sudden flash and died without even a chance to scream. He had barely survived. He crawled toward the Blood Lord, hoping the great Apostle chosen by the Lord of Heaven would ease his pain, even a little.

And the Blood Lord answered his desperate plea.

With the weight of a thousand geun[3844] behind his foot.

Crunch!

The man's spine shattered. That was the end of it.

The Blood Lord didn't know whether the man had been grasping at the last thread of life or hoping for the peace of death.

No, that wasn't quite right. The death of a nobody, little more than a disposable pawn, had never interested him in the first place.

His gaze had been fixed all along beyond the thick cloud of dust.

"Come out."

The instant his cold voice left his lips—

Whoosh!

A flash burst from the dust and hurtled toward him.

More precisely, it was heat that shone like a flash of light.

Fwoosh—BOOM!

Flames swept through the air.

Their terrible heat turned suspicion into certainty. The Blood Lord brought the Red Blade down with all his might.

Slice!

The flames split to either side with a sharp cutting sound.

[3844] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is about 600 kg (1,320 lb).

The avenue, more than twenty jang[3845] wide, was engulfed in fire. Through the rising heat haze, a figure wavered.

"Where are you in such a hurry to go?"

The voice was low and steady.

Even through the heat haze, the eyes pouring out flames shone clearly.

Fire King Jeok Cheongang.

The Blood Lord's eyes narrowed at the sight of him. He hadn't expected Jeok to appear yet. Perhaps he had thought he would never see him again.

"So the head of the Ten Kings, whom the orthodox faction praises so highly, is just another warrior after all. You abandoned all those allies to save your one and only disciple?"

Certain Jeok had deserted the North Gate to come here, the Blood Lord spoke with scorn.

Jeok Cheongang caught his breath before replying. "I never asked anyone to praise me. But there's a reason for everything."

"What?"

"Ever since the day I defeated a thousand demonic soldiers, the world has called me the Fire King. It's been so long I was starting to tire of the name… Perhaps that will change after today."

"…!"

The Blood Lord's face twisted as he finally understood what Jeok's arrival meant.

The Potala Palace forces sent to the North Gate had been formidable. There was the Dalai Lama, Tibet's greatest master, and the Twelve Secret Monks, who included two Supreme Peak masters, greenhorns though they were.

Two Black Ghosts had been sent as well, in case anything unexpected happened. They should have been capable of more than holding Jeok in place. It wouldn't have been surprising if they'd killed him.

But how?

The Blood Lord had no answer to the question that sprang to mind. Perhaps he never would.

The battle between those fighting to protect something and those consumed entirely by revenge could often defy expectations by a wide margin.

And Fire King Jeok Cheongang had someone he would protect even at the cost of everything he had.

"Did you think a few bald monks like that could stop this old man?"

The Blood Lord clenched his teeth at the low voice.

"You crazy old bastard. No matter how hard you struggle, nothing will change."

"I have protected him. And I will protect him."

[3845] A jang is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

“That precious disciple of yours? The one who might be dying right now?”

“…What did you say?”

Jeok Cheongang faltered. The Blood Lord’s mouth twisted into a smile.

“No. Perhaps he’s already dead. Last I saw him, he was at death’s door.”

“You dare…!”

The news of his disciple’s danger shook Jeok more than he could hide.

Whoosh!

With a faint whistle of air, the Blood Lord vanished like a phantom. He crossed more than ten jang and struck.

Slice!

The ground split like tofu.

Jeok Cheongang twisted aside just in time to avoid the blow, but blood spurted from several places on his body.

Drip, drip, drip!

The force of the blade was enough to wound him without touching him.

Jeok knew better than anyone what that blood scattering through the air meant.

My body…!

It felt as heavy as a thousand geun. Even his senses were slow to respond.

In his anger and desperation, he had forgotten how exhausted the battle at the North Gate had left him—and how badly a moment’s emotional turmoil could cost him in a life-and-death duel.

The Blood Lord saw it, too.

BOOM!

Blade strikes tore through the air like a storm.

Dozens—no, hundreds—of attacks poured back and forth, as though slicing time itself apart. Already exhausted, Jeok Cheongang sensed that this fight was close to its end.

He knew that end would be his death. He also knew he had one move left that might change it.

Dance of the Fire God and Demon.

A final flame fueled by everything he had.

The divine art had been passed down through generations of the Fire Gate Clan, yet its terrible aftermath had made it forbidden. Jeok Cheongang had nearly died from using it once already.

But now it was all he had left. It was the only way to defeat the Blood Lord, whose power came closer to Regeneration than mere healing.

Even that brief moment of thought might have been more than Jeok could afford.

An opening!

The Blood Lord's eyes flashed.

Whoom!

The Red Blade was buried deep in the ground. Instead, he drove a fist toward Jeok's side like a cannonball, putting all his strength behind it.

For some reason, his strength and speed had grown greater still since Jin Taekyung's One Annihilation had put him in danger.

"…!"

Jeok had no time even to gasp.

His body was exhausted, his senses dulled, and his internal energy was nearly spent. All he could do was cross his Force-clad arms and brace with everything he had.

BOOM!

His vision overturned.

The blow hurled Jeok more than ten jang through the air and straight through a large inn that had once been crowded with people.

CRASH!

A pillar collapsed. Splinters flew.

Not until he had smashed through seven buildings, beginning with the inn, did Jeok cough up the hot surge rising from his gut.

Splatter.

Blackened blood stained an alley he didn't recognize.

Through his blurring vision, he saw the Blood Lord rushing toward him like a gale. Joy and killing intent burned together in those blood-red eyes.

"Jeok Cheongang!"

The Blood Lord roared his name and brought the Red Blade down.

CLANG!

A sharp crash rang out.

The Blood Lord was forced back, eyes wide with disbelief, after deflecting five streaks of light fired from an unexpected angle.

Whoooom.

A vibration ran through his grip.

The Red Blade trembled, then steadied. The Blood Lord's face, twisted like a Fiend's, did not.

"Not bad… But after living this long, you ought to know when to stay out of a fight. Don't you think?"

He slowly turned his head as he growled.

His blood-red gaze fell on the five old men standing between him and Jeok Cheongang.

"If you don't want to be torn limb from limb and die."

Despite the killing intent bearing down on them, the slender old Daoist at their center quietly helped Jeok to his feet.

Fwoosh.

Internal energy flowed into Jeok, and a little color returned to his deathly pale face. He coughed up another mouthful of blood.

“Thank you for all your hard work,” the old Daoist said calmly. “We’ll take it from here.”

“Cough. You’re…”

“Jin Taekyung may not have much time left.”

“…!”

“Go. Quickly. It’s for everyone’s sake, too.”

Of course, the old Daoist’s “everyone” left out one person.

“Ha. Now there are six crazy old men.”

Sneering, the Blood Lord angled the Red Blade downward.

“Then you can all die.”

Whoosh!

A crescent of blood-red Force shot along the Red Blade. The Force alone was a full jang across, and the strike carried terrifying power.

The next instant—

BOOM!

A crash like the sky splitting apart rang out. Everything within a ten-jang radius crumbled to dust.

Above it stood six figures, high in the air.

“…!”

The Blood Lord’s gaze darkened. The slender old Daoist bowed his head slightly to Jeok Cheongang, whom he had been supporting.

“Please forgive the impertinence of one so far your junior.”

Jeok was too drained to answer. Severe exhaustion and Internal Injury had been building since the North Gate.

No—there wasn’t even time for an answer. Before he could speak, the old Daoist’s arms swung with force.

“You crazy—!”

The Blood Lord’s frantic shout came too late.

Whoooosh!

Jeok Cheongang shot through the air toward the Inner City.

Before the enraged Blood Lord could pursue him, the five old Daoists landed softly on the ground and blocked his way.

They had the bearing of immortals, an aura like noble cranes, and a movement technique astonishing enough to match.

Only then did the Blood Lord recognize the intruders.

“The Kunlun Five Immortals.”

“You know us?”

“How could I not? I’ve heard the heartbreaking tale of five old men who should have died long ago, still eating up the Kunlun Sect’s rice.”

Naturally, the Blood Lord’s account bore little resemblance to their reputation.

The Kunlun Five Immortals were Martial Uncles to Cheongheoja, the current Sect Leader, and Elders who still upheld the Kunlun Sect well into their eighties.

Each had stopped just short of Supreme Peak. But they had grown up as close as brothers, and their combined technique was said to withstand even a Supreme Peak master.

To the Blood Lord, they were merely five more troublesome old moths.

“Get out of my sight. I’d tear you apart right now, but even that would waste time.”

The slender old Daoist, the eldest of the Kunlun Five Immortals, Perfected One Taecheong, shook his head.

“I cannot accept that offer. So I’d like to suggest an alternative.”

“There is no alternative. You’ve just thrown away your last chance.”

The Blood Lord let the Red Blade hang at an angle and stepped toward them.

First Jin Taekyung. Now Jeok Cheongang. Twice he had lost prey he’d nearly caught—prey he had to kill.

Their auras felt far stronger than their reputations suggested. That was puzzling, but even a combined technique capable of facing a Supreme Peak master would be a tower built on sand before him. It would fall in moments.

Or so he’d thought.

“You’re mistaken,” the old Daoist said. “We still have a chance.”

“What?”

“This is the alternative we came up with.”

Only then did the Blood Lord notice the calm smile on Perfected One Taecheong’s lips. Something was wrong.

Shaaaaa.

Power surged from Perfected One Taecheong—no, from all five of the Kunlun Five Immortals—and shook the air around them.

Their fierce aura was hard to believe in men whose skill was said to have stopped at the very edge of Peak. It was so rough, it made the immortal meaning of their title seem absurd.

It took the Blood Lord little time to recognize what felt so familiar about it.

“You… Don’t tell me.”

“It’s as fearsome as I heard, this Temporary Strength Pill.”

“…!”

“No need to look so surprised. None of us has ever practiced demonic martial arts. We had to pay a price to take it.”

Perfected One Taecheong was telling the truth.

The Temporary Strength Pill’s power was chiefly for practitioners of demonic, heterodox arts—particularly those whose martial arts remained incomplete because they had not reached Supreme Peak.

Even if someone who cultivated pure qi took one of the spare pills carried by Dark Heaven’s followers, it would have little effect.

Unless they did something mad: broke the innate qi they had built up over more than eighty years and forced themselves to absorb the pill’s energy.

“To stop a monster…”

Whoooom.

His words faded beneath a deep rumble.

An unstable, hazy Force gathered around the sword in Perfected One Taecheong’s hand. There was no mistaking what it was.

And it wasn’t his sword alone. Force rose from the blades of all five Kunlun Five Immortals.

“If that’s what it takes, then we’ll gladly become monsters, too.”

Whoosh!

Space split, and six figures clashed in a tangle.

Fifteen minutes.

That was all the time the Kunlun Five Immortals remained on their feet.

But for someone else, they had bought a full fifteen minutes.

Perhaps that was why Perfected One Taecheong could smile even through the overwhelming pain as both his legs were torn off.

Slice!

Then his arms were severed.

Boom!

Even as the organs inside him tore apart, he swallowed his screams.

And when the shadow of death finally fell over him, the old Daoist held fast to his principles and offered a last farewell to his Junior Brothers, whose breathing had already ceased.

“Remember… Our deaths will not be in vain…”

Crack!

His brain matter burst out with a horrible pop.

The Blood Lord lifted his foot from Perfected One Taecheong's shattered head.

"No. This is a meaningless death."

As he slowly raised his head, cries sounded from every direction, louder and closer than before.

No. It was a creed of exactly eight characters.

Above heaven and below heaven, ten thousand demons bow in homage.

Above heaven and below heaven, let all things kneel.

"…So it shall be."

Leaving those low words behind, the monster continued toward the Inner City.

Sticky blood followed in his wake.

Chapter 1115

It was a fierce battle.

Unprecedented in a thousand years of Murim history, stretching back to the day a monk from a distant land crossed the Yangtze on a single reed leaf.[3846]

It was a bloodbath, too.

One without precedent in the history of the entire continent, not just Murim.

CRUNCH!

A skull split open. Brain matter sprayed.

The boy died without so much as a final cry.

But no one grieved anymore for a boy soldier who hadn't even reached twenty.

No—they couldn't.

In the relentless turning of this brutal hellscape, death had long since become cheap.

The only thing they could do for the dead was take revenge.

"The Lord of Heaven is with us…!"

A bloodshot fanatic trampled the boy's corpse as he stepped onto the wall.

Thud.

A gleaming blade burst out between his brows.

"Who's with you?"

The fanatic, already dead, couldn't answer.

A small shadow pulled the dagger from the back of his head as the body crumpled like a rotten log. Then the shadow stepped toward the other enemies, still elated at having seized the wall.

Whoosh.

The figure vanished like a ghost.

The Sword Energy that came flying a beat too late shot toward the space where the shadow had stood, but a cool breeze from somewhere had already swept past them.

Slice—SPLAT!

A fountain of blood arced into the pitch-black night sky.

The speed was blinding, every movement precise and free of waste. Yet after cutting down dozens of enemies in the blink of an eye, the shadow—the Slaughter Saint—looked grim.

This is the limit. We can't hold out any longer.

He wasn't thinking only of himself.

[3846] The reed-leaf crossing is a legend about Bodhidharma, the monk traditionally associated with the beginnings of Chan Buddhism in China.

The South Gate had been an impregnable fortress with the Slaughter Saint and the Bow Saint defending it. Now the gate was faltering, along with every defender stationed there.

It's a miracle we held out this long.

Perhaps the fight had been impossible from the start.

Their side had even needed to call up commoners, while the enemy were all trained in a certain level of martial arts and had used Temporary Strength Pills as well.

Outmatched in both numbers and quality, they had held on only by making the most of their defensive position and deploying their handful of elite troops wherever they were needed.

But—

So this is as far as we go.

The Slaughter Saint swallowed a groan and looked around.

Beyond the unrelenting downpour lay a sea of corpses and blood. His allies were collapsing from exhaustion, their bodies pushed far past the limits of their will.

Everyone was tired.

Their limbs felt as heavy as waterlogged cotton. Keeping their minds from giving way was all they could manage.

Even the Slaughter Saint felt his exhaustion mounting and his dantian running empty.

If only we'd taken out the Grand Sorceress. We might have had a chance to counterattack…

But the Grand Sorceress was no easy opponent. She was even more formidable than he'd heard.

The defenses around her and the hundred or so other mages had been as solid as an iron wall. When the Slaughter Saint threw everything he had into breaking through to its center, he found no fewer than four Black Ghosts waiting for him.

All four had been strengthened by an array of enhancement spells.

Without help from the greatest archer under Heaven, who could tear a target apart from hundreds of jang[3847] away, even the Slaughter Saint would not have returned with all his limbs intact.

Still, he had brought down two Black Ghosts. Pride and sheer determination had seen to that.

Shing!

A brilliant flash shattered his brief reverie.

BOOM!

[3847] A jang is a traditional length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

A massive beam of light swallowed the twenty or so fanatics charging at him from behind and exploded.

"You seem relaxed. You even have time to look away."

At the Bow Saint's pointed remark, the Slaughter Saint flicked his sleeve.

Thud-thud-thud!

Enemies aiming their bows from blind spots crumpled all at once, each with a long, slender ox-hair needle embedded between the brows.

"I wish I looked relaxed. Maybe then those bastards would be a little scared."

"Do you think they have any fear left?"

"…Damn it."

The Slaughter Saint launched himself forward again with a bitter curse, trying to protect as many of his allies as he could from fiends who had mortgaged their very souls to fanatic faith.

Slice! CRACK!

He cut and stabbed, broke bones and twisted limbs.

But that was all he could do.

No matter how tirelessly the two giants who had once shone so brightly in their age cut down their enemies, the exhausted defenders' resistance faded fast. The fanatics' fervent voices filled the wall.

"Great Lord of Heaven!"

"Let your majesty and power descend upon this land!"

Grit.

Facing them felt like standing before an enormous wave. The Slaughter Saint clenched his teeth without realizing it.

Kill hundreds, and thousands followed. Cut down thousands, and tens of thousands stood behind them.

Would this battle ever end?

What the hell are we supposed to do…?

He couldn't even finish the thought.

He was a man of flesh and blood, not an all-knowing, all-powerful god.

…This is the first time I've wanted to see someone this badly.

Was it the wounds scattered across his body? Or the internal energy draining away even now?

Caught in the exhaustion and emptiness he'd forgotten, the Slaughter Saint suddenly thought of someone who, long ago, had always brought him confidence and certain victory—even when facing a Demonic Cult army more than ten times their size.

Martial God, what would you have done?

It was a foolish question.

The Martial God would never have entertained such doubts in the first place. That was the kind of man he was.

A true heaven, beyond the reach of even the three brightest stars in all Murim.

And yet, at that moment, another name came to the Slaughter Saint.

Jin Taekyung.

The master of the Morning Star, the new star Dharma King Hong Dao had once spoken of—and now the young man who had drawn the Lord of Heaven's inexplicable obsession.

And—

The Chosen One.

The Slaughter Saint could be sure of nothing.

Was it all coincidence? Or had someone high above, in the distant heavens, decided their fate long ago?

All he could do was hold tight to their one hope, even if it amounted to no more than a handful.

Slice!

Force streamed from his dagger as it cut through the air, bending like a whip to sweep across the wall.

Amid severed limbs and spilling blood, the Slaughter Saint drew on what little internal energy he had left and slaughtered the enemies before him in a single attack. Then he opened his mouth.

"Everyone, retreat."

…!

…!

The defenders, barely managing to resist, stared at him wide-eyed. But he had made up his mind. His voice did not waver.

"Messenger, take word to the South and North Gates immediately. The elites stationed at each gate will cover the rear and buy us some time. The rest of the troops are to retreat as quickly and orderly as possible."

Silence pressed down on them. It lasted only an instant, but felt like an eternity.

To them, abandoning the wall meant that the word they'd been trying so hard to ignore—defeat—was finally becoming real.

Only one person present could oppose the Slaughter Saint's decision. The Bow Saint watched him, her gaze still calm.

Is that the best we can do, then?

Her Sound Transmission reached his ear.

The Slaughter Saint met her gaze and answered just as calmly.

I don't know. But… I want to believe.

That was all.

He wanted to believe in the one person chosen by Dharma King Hong Dao, who had read the heavenly patterns; by the Blood Lord, who had thrown even those patterns into disarray; and by the Martial God, whose life or death was now unknown.

I want to see with my own eyes where coincidence ends and fate begins.

Even if a wretched end awaited him, he would not regret it.

The young brat he had watched as Mungyeong, not as the Slaughter Saint, had the makings of a Great Master worth risking his life for, regardless of age or martial prowess.

Surely they all felt the same.

Bow Saint.

At his quiet call, he looked steadily at her.

I don't know exactly what you have in mind. But there's one thing I do know. No—anyone who's been even a little close to Jin Taekyung knows it.

…

You can keep your distance and refuse to say a word, but you can't bring yourself to hate that boy.

…!

I want to believe in him. And in you, too.

Her pupils wavered for an instant.

But neither her agitation nor her silence lasted long.

Fwoosh!

High above them, enormous balls of fire came pouring down like a meteor shower, evaporating even the driving rain.

Shing!

The Bow Saint's hand moved like lightning. A dazzling arrow of light shot forth.

KABOOM!

A crash that seemed to split heaven and earth rang out, and the sky turned red.

The fireballs broke into hundreds, then thousands of pieces, large and small, and rained down. The Bow Saint watched them fall, her face set.

"Honestly, I don't know what choice I should make."

The Slaughter Saint was about to groan when she added quietly, "Still, I want to believe, too."

…!

"Come with me. To the Inner City. To that boy."

At last, a faint smile touched the Slaughter Saint's tired lips.

Chapter 1116

Xining Fortress, the last line of defense in Qinghai, was well suited to withstanding a siege.

But in the dozens of battles fought over the years, its high, sturdy walls had not been the only thing to give invaders nightmares.

“As expected, even those Fiends are having trouble crossing the moat.”

At the middle-aged Daoist’s admiring murmur, Cheongheoja, Sect Leader of the Kunlun Sect, nodded.

“Without it, this fight would be twice as hard. The gate would have fallen long ago.”

Even now, the moat—which was more than ten jang[3848] wide and quite deep—was forcing the enemy to pay a terrible price.

And crossing it was only the beginning. Beyond it waited a gate made of immensely thick black iron. No matter how skilled Dark Heaven’s fanatics were in martial arts, they had little choice but to suffer the losses and scale the walls instead.

The walls had been in danger at times, thanks perhaps to the enemy’s overwhelming numbers and the strength granted by their Temporary Strength Pills. But here at the East Gate, the defense was holding more easily than anywhere else.

If they could keep it that way, they might even win.

The middle-aged Daoist beside Cheongheoja seemed to share that hope.

“If we win this battle, we can all return to the main sect together, can’t we?”

“All of us together… How wonderful that would be.”

Cheongheoja’s voice was heavier than ever. The middle-aged Daoist’s expression turned bitter.

“Are you thinking about your second Disciple?”

Cheongheoja was silent for a moment, then shook his head.

“No.”

“Then…”

“I was thinking about the shortcomings of a foolish master who failed to guide his Disciple down the right path.”

“…!”

“It was my fault. From beginning to end. All of it.”

“Master…”

[3848] A jang is a traditional Korean length of about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Ten jang is about 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

The middle-aged Daoist—Cheongheoja's Senior Disciple, Hak Su—looked at him with sorrow.

"Don't blame yourself. It wasn't your fault."

"Is that what you think?"

"I know it. Everyone in Kunlun does. You kept your second Disciple closer than anyone else and took special care of him."

"I had to. You were always gentle, and your third Junior Brother was full of energy. But that child always seemed rough and unsettled."

"Wasn't that why you gave him the Daoist name Hak Eui?"

"Yes. That was why."

The boy who had grown up in dark, dangerous back alleys had gained a new name and a family. Cheongheoja had always urged his rough-tempered second Disciple to live up to that name and become a more righteous man.

To never forget, even for an instant, that he was a Daoist.

"But… who could have guessed he was a spy conspiring with Dark Heaven?"

Hak Su pressed his lips together and shook his head.

"I still can't believe it. I don't want to."

His gaze shifted to the empty space beside him, as though his second Junior Brother might be standing there with his usual crooked look.

But that would never happen.

No. It was impossible.

Hak Eui was already dead.

Before dawn, he had resisted those who came under cover of night to capture the spy. In the end, he had lost his life.

Hak Su had arrived at the scene too late. He'd seen his master holding his Junior Brother's severed head and a sword dripping with blood.

He'd seen his master with eyes sadder than ever—just like now.

"Master…"

Just as Hak Su looked at Cheongheoja, torn by conflicting thoughts—

Whoosh!

A sharp whistle cut through the air. A messenger came racing toward them, using his movement technique with all his might.

"Sect Leader!"

He was covered in blood, and his face was as white as a sheet.

Cheongheoja swallowed the groan that almost escaped him and spoke in a heavy voice.

"Where have you come from?"

"The South Gate. Hah… The South Gate."

“Then the two Seniors have ordered a retreat to the Inner City?”

“How did you…?”

“I understand. It must be much the same elsewhere.”

No further words were needed. The messenger’s appearance had told Cheongheoja enough. He went on calmly.

“Go and tell them I’ll lead the East Gate forces to the Inner City shortly.”

“May fortune favor you in battle.”

The messenger bowed briefly and left. Hak Su’s face hardened.

“Go ahead without me. I’ll stay with some of the troops and buy you time.”

His eyes and voice were full of resolve, but Cheongheoja shook his head at once.

“I can’t leave you behind.”

Hearing the concern in his master’s voice, Hak Su gave a faint smile.

“The road to the Inner City won’t be easy. It may be even more dangerous than staying here. They need you more than they need me.”

It was a reasonable prediction.

The dire news that the West Gate had fallen to the Blood Lord had reached the East Gate just before the war drums were about to be destroyed.

Unlike the East Gate, where the enemy forces were comparatively weaker than at the other three gates, a retreat without a plan might lead them straight into the Blood Lord and his fanatics, who could be rampaging unchecked through the fortress from the West Gate.

Even so, Cheongheoja would not yield.

“I forbid it.”

“Master, we’re out of time!”

Hak Su could no longer contain his urgency. But then—

“Who is out of time?”

Cheongheoja’s voice sank strangely low, piercing Hak Su’s ear.

“Master…?”

“I asked who was out of time.”

Hak Su blinked at him, bewildered.

The old Daoist’s presence had changed so suddenly that the Kunlun Disciples who knew him well—and all the soldiers nearby—were staring at Cheongheoja.

Then an unexpected voice rang through the rain.

“Why hesitate? Your master, lofty as the heavens, has asked you a question.”

Splash.

A foot came down in a puddle, accompanied by a hard-edged voice.

At the same time, a man who looked to be around thirty took off his low-pulled straw hat. He stared at Hak Su with cold eyes and continued:

“Answer him, Senior Brother.”

“…!”

“…!”

A shock swept across the wall.

No, it was more than shock.

A man they believed dead had appeared before them.

While most stood frozen, Hak Su studied his Junior Brother in silence. Then he spoke calmly.

“I thought you were dead.”

“If that’s how it looked, then I was.”

Hak Eui’s face was set as he rubbed the neck that had supposedly been severed the night before.

“The fool who truly cared about you is already dead. And before dawn, I was born anew.”

“Then the head I saw…”

“You seem to have forgotten how crowded Xining’s underground prison is.”

Only then did Hak Su remember. A few days earlier, the Qinghai City Lord and several other leaders had been dragged into the streets and executed on the spot. Even after that, well over a hundred prisoners remained in the underground prison awaiting judgment.

And there was someone who could find one built like Hak Eui and make a human-skin mask convincing enough to fool them all.

“The Slaughter Saint.”

Hak Su murmured the name to himself and gave a small nod.

“So that’s what happened.”

His calm acceptance drew uneasy murmurs from those who had been watching, still hoping they were wrong.

Hak Su. It was him.

He was the traitor working with Dark Heaven.

The Kunlun Sect Leader’s Senior Disciple had betrayed the sect to which he had belonged for thirty years.

Cheongheoja looked at the Disciple he had wanted to believe in until the very end. His expression was impossible to describe.

“Why…?”

Hak Su slowly opened his mouth.

“Do not ask why. Do not question. Think only of the mission you’ve been given.”

It was an answer, and a memory: words a child born in a land beyond the distant desert had heard countless times before he turned thirteen.

A duty and a mission etched into his bones, impossible to defy even after decades.

“Heaven above and earth below, let ten thousand demons bow in homage.”

“…!”

“That is everything. I need no other reason.”

Hak Su looked directly into the trembling eyes of the man he had called Master. His face and voice were nothing like they had been before.

“I used to tell you that meeting you by Qinghai Lake was the greatest luck of my life.”

He had meant it.

No one deserved to be called a Daoist more than Cheongheoja. He had accepted his meeting with a boy wandering near Qinghai Lake as fate, never knowing the boy had made it look like chance.

“Thank you. I had no great martial talent. Even I never thought I’d rise this far.”

But Cheongheoja had cared nothing for status or talent. Even if the Kunlun Sect had not suffered such devastating losses in the Great Faction War, he would gladly have taken Hak Su as his Disciple.

Just as Hak Su had been raised to be a spy, Cheongheoja had always been that kind of man.

“It was all thanks to you, Cheongheoja.”

The instant a clear smile came to Hak Su’s lips—

“Hak Su, how dare you—!”

Hak Eui could bear no more. With an angry roar, he shot forward.

He was not the only one charging at the man who had betrayed their sect.

Whoosh!

Swift movement techniques. Formidable auras.

The Kunlun Ten Guests—regarded as the future Elders who would succeed the Kunlun Five Immortals, and as indispensable pillars of the sect—drew their swords without hesitation.

Slice!

A flash of steel cut into a torso. Hot blood gushed out.

Splatter. Thud, thud.

Blood sprayed across the wall.

Cheongheoja had stepped in front of Hak Eui. Over his master’s shoulder, Hak Eui saw something he could scarcely believe.

“What…?”

“I was getting tired of being called Hak Su.”

Hak Su—or rather, Dark Heaven’s spy—looked at the five corpses lying with severed throats and pierced hearts. Then he slowly raised his head.

Beside him stood the other shadows who had infiltrated the Kunlun Sect before him, or around the same time.

“Number Six. That is my name.”

At that moment—

Crunch.

The Kunlun Five Guests—the five remaining members, spies raised by Dark Heaven—took the Temporary Strength Pills hidden in their robes and chewed them.

Sssssss!

A vast wave of energy rose like wildfire. Through it, Cheongheoja’s low voice rang out.

“I truly cannot leave you behind.”

Chapter 1117

Today, there was nowhere in Xining where the word peace could be found.

Not to the east, west, south, or north. Not even in the sky.

Rain and blood drenched everything, while screams and crashes rang out without pause.

And yet there was one exception: a hill rising tall several hundred jang[3849] from the East Gate.

It's really coming down out there.

Hardly the sort of thought someone in a life-or-death crisis could afford to have.

As he watched the sky pour down thick sheets of rain, as though a giant hole had opened overhead, the black-robed man suddenly turned east.

Whoooosh.

In the deep darkness, a fierce, stormlike wind whipped waves across the water.

After days of unprecedented rain without a moment's pause, what had once been a fairly level stretch of ground had become something that could easily be called a river.

Of course, that wasn't what the black-robed man was looking for.

"Have they arrived?"

His companion's question came out of nowhere.

"Not yet."

"They're later than expected. They should've been here by now."

"If they were diligent enough to keep to a schedule, why would they spend their lives robbing people?"

His companion gave a quiet laugh of agreement beneath his low-pulled black hood.

"But I didn't think they'd be this stupid. They may be rootless bandits, but if they dare call themselves an Alliance, I thought they'd have at least a little skill or sense."

"Maybe this is the result of them thinking things through, in their own way."

"What do you mean?"

"Even fools can guess when they're being used as cannon fodder. Most of them are petty bandits, but their leaders—the Seafaring King and the Green Forest Battle King—know how to use their heads."

"So they're deliberately dragging their feet to minimize their losses?"

"The weather's gotten worse, too, but it's certainly possible."

"Even with nearly ten thousand of our people watching those bandits?"

[3849] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

"Who knows? Those water ghosts of the Yangtze River Channel League might pull something if they put their minds to it, no matter how closely we watch."

"Ha. If that's true, they're not just stupid. They're beyond saving."

The black-robed man nodded as his companion clicked his tongue.

Neither had said it outright, but everyone in Dark Heaven knew how cruel the Blood Lord could be once he began rampaging with no thought for what came after.

If the combined forces of the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance arrived only after the fighting was over…

After today, the Central Plains will be clean. You won't find so much as a hair from one of those bandits.

But they still had a chance to survive.

If they arrived in time, before the East Gate opened as planned, and earned even a little credit to save face, they might extend their stubborn lives a while longer.

Of course, that depended on the Blood Lord's mood.

If you want to live, row with every last bit of strength you've got. It'll save us both a headache.

The black-robed man looked toward the East Gate, where the battle was raging.

What did he care whether a bunch of bandits lived or died? But for someone Dark Heaven classified as a corpse sorcerer, it mattered quite a lot.

His role was less that of a soldier fighting on the battlefield than a member of the crew hauling away the corpses scattered across it.

And while he worried about the extra work, the battle around the East Gate, which had been seesawing back and forth, suddenly took a sharp turn.

BOOOOM!

A deafening crash rang out.

It swallowed the sound of the rain and even the occasional thunder. The black-robed man and his companion stared wide-eyed.

The top of the fortress wall was collapsing amid a burst of light.

"What was that…?"

The black-robed man's words came out as a groan.

The flash had lasted only an instant, but he was sure. The destructive energy still flaring across the wall was Force.

Why? We haven't even pressed the attack. Why would Cheongheoja…?

The Kunlun Sect Leader came to mind, but the black-robed man shook his head.

POP! RUMMMBLE!

Another distant flash burst into view. Its pale, ominous light could hardly have come from Daoist martial arts.

"It's not the Black Ghosts, either. They're still holding their positions as ordered."

His companion was right.

The two Black Ghosts were waiting on the battlefield in front of the wall, along with a considerable number of troops the Blood Lord had deliberately held back.

“Which means…”

The black-robed man stopped.

If that Force belonged to neither Cheongheoja nor a Black Ghost, there was only one possibility.

Spies.

The spies they had planted in the Kunlun Sect over many years had finally made their move—a step ahead of schedule.

“What do we do?”

The black-robed man bit his lip.

It was a real pain in the ass.

The combined forces of the Yangtze River Channel League and the Green Forest Alliance, who should have arrived at the battlefield by now, were still nowhere to be seen. Meanwhile, the spies who were supposed to open the East Gate were caught up in an unexpected fight.

To make matters worse, Ma Sanbao—effectively their direct superior—wasn’t there today. The black-robed man would have to make the call himself.

And fast.

He stared at the East Gate, torn between his options. The moment was brief, though it felt like an eternity. Then his eyes widened.

CLANK. GRRRRNNG!

The iron bridge began to move with a heavy grinding sound.

The massive bridge connected to the moat in front of the gate. It was coming down like a ray of light.

The bridge is connected to the gate. It can only be operated from inside.

It was clear proof that the spies planted in the Kunlun Sect were opening the gate—and the perfect opportunity.

There was no point hesitating any longer.

“I command you: answer the call!”

The black-robed man pulled the ritual bell from his belt and shook it hard.

Wooooong.

A sinister sound carried on the wind, its vibrations spreading outward.

The hill they had been standing on answered. Or rather, the enormous masses of flesh that the rain and chaos had made look like a hill did.

GRRRRKK!

The ground shook as if an earthquake had struck. A horrible corpse stench rose through the rain and mud.

BOOM. BOOOOM!

The monsters shook off the mud plastered over their bodies and stood on limbs as thick as great trees. There were a thousand in all.

Perched on one monster's shoulder, the black-robed man shook his ritual bell again and whispered, "Wipe them all out."

At that instant—

—KROOOAAAR!

With a roar as immense as their bodies, a thousand monsters surged toward the battlefield like a wave.

THUDDUDDUDDUD!

Was this what the Yellow River would look like in flood?

Screams rose belatedly from the wall as the defenders spotted the monsters bearing down on them with unstoppable momentum. But those weren't the only enemies they had to face.

"All. Troops."

"Charge."

A low voice emerged from beneath black armor.

At the same time, the two Black Ghosts who had been waiting sprang forward.

SHWOOOSH!

A ghost horse, its white bones exposed, raced ahead like the wind. Several thousand fanatics charged behind it, their cries shaking the battlefield.

"Heaven above and earth below! Let ten thousand demons bow in homage!"

"The Lord of Heaven is with us!"

The immense shouts behind him sent a thrilling shiver up the black-robed man's spine.

Things had strayed a little from the original plan, but those minor setbacks no longer mattered.

He had an army at his back. And beyond the iron bridge, which had descended nearly halfway…

I see it!

There was no doubt. He wasn't seeing things.

As the iron bridge lowered on its chains, the enormous iron gate began to open. The sight was clear in the black-robed man's eyes, brimming with delight.

Tss-tss-tss-tss!

The two corpse sorcerers shook their ritual bells with confident sweeps of their hands. The monsters pushed themselves to their limit and shot toward the East Gate.

We can do this.

Time seemed to slow. The black-robed man held his breath and watched the battlefield.

Flashes of light flickered without pause atop the wall, which was shrouded in crashes and dust. The bridge, more than halfway down, now covered the moat.

Only a little over a hundred jang[3850] remained.

Faster. Faster...!

The monsters leading the charge thundered forward, their footsteps like thunderclaps. Beside them, the ghost horse carrying the two Black Ghosts galloped as if it were a specter.

Whoooosh!

A fierce wind wrapped around the black-robed man. His heart pounded as the distance shrank.

A little over a hundred jang[3851] became half that.

Then half again.

And at last—

GRRRNNG. BOOM!

The long, sturdy iron bridge settled over the moat.

BOOOOM!

The two Black Ghosts crossed first. Behind them, a thousand monsters surged toward the wide-open gate like one enormous spear.

KRRRRRUNCH!

A terrifying crash sent dust billowing into the air. The black-robed man and his companion had finally broken through the barrier of the East Gate, and they let out the breaths they had been holding.

They had done it. By their own strength.

No one could dispute their success—or the magnitude of their feat.

Even the merciless Blood Lord would have to acknowledge it.

For that moment, at least, both men could rejoice.

SHWING—BOOM!

Then a dazzling flash of Force flew in from somewhere and shattered the thick chain connecting the gate and the iron bridge.

CLANK. RRRRRK!

It happened too quickly for anyone to react.

"...!"

"...!"

The two corpse sorcerers stared blankly as the heavy gate began to close. Beyond the settling dust, a hazy figure came into view.

[3850] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

[3851] A *jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length equal to ten *ja*, about 3.03 meters or 9.94 feet.

SPLASH. SPLASH.

Staggering steps. A robe soaked in blood.

Then the middle-aged man's face emerged, his eyes glowing red as if to prove he had committed a forbidden act.

"…You."

The black-robed man slowly parted his lips.

At that moment—

Slice!

A streak of light cut through the dust and across the middle-aged man's—no, Hak Su's—neck.

A voice rang out, thick with sorrow and anger.

"By the solemn rules of the Great Kunlun Sect, I execute the criminals of our sect."

THUD. FWOOSH.

The headless body collapsed, and the dust cloud parted.

Only then did the two corpse sorcerers see their surroundings clearly. Only then did they understand.

The spies hadn't lowered the bridge and opened the gate. The defenders of the East Gate had.

A trap…!

The realization struck like lightning.

But the shock lasted only a moment. There were fewer than three thousand defenders, and Cheongheoja looked exhausted. The black-robed man's lips twisted into a grin.

"You dare try such a shoddy trick?"

It was a trap—but at the same time, it wasn't.

The gate had shut out the fanatics following them, but their strongest forces—the Black Ghosts and the monsters—were already inside.

"Did you think this would stop us?"

A young man standing beside Cheongheoja answered his scornful question.

"Why not? We've been through a whole lot worse. Right, everyone?"

The black-robed man frowned at him. There was something about the young man's face that made him want to torment him.

Just then, a young beggar with grime streaming down his face spoke up.

"Quit calling me a beggar. It hurts the feelings of the beggar listening."

"Who the hell are you…?"

"Honestly, we end up in situations like this every time. I can't even figure out how much extra pay we're owed anymore."

A cold-faced young man cut him off. Then a clear voice, utterly at odds with the mood, rang out.

“But we always made it through. Together.”

“True, but this time is different. The most important person isn’t here.”

“Right. Taishan wants to eat Pavilion Master. Old Man Nam, too.”

“Taishan. You mean you miss them, not that you want to eat them.”

“Oh. Got mixed up. My lord is smart, as expected.”

“Not bad. Still, not as good as me.”

Young men and women the corpse sorcerers had never seen before. A hulking man who looked none too bright. A wild-haired eccentric.

Faced with the bizarre sight, the two sorcerers couldn’t think of anything to ask.

More precisely, they didn’t think it was worth asking.

“Wipe them all out.”

The ritual bell began to move with his quiet mutter.

Boooooo!

A horn sounded in the distance, and everyone at the East Gate stopped moving.

For some, that sound meant hope. For others, utter despair.

“The Yangtze River Channel League…”

Someone’s low groan hung heavily in the air.

Chapter 1118

Boooooo!

The horn sounded far away, reaching the defenders at the East Gate. For a moment, they found themselves wishing it belonged to reinforcements coming to help them.

But the truth was cruel and unmistakable.

“The Yangtze River Channel League…”

The groan that slipped from someone’s lips spoke for every defender there.

They could not see its source, but they heard it clearly.

Not the west. Not the south. Not the north.

It came from beyond the East Gate wall where they stood. That could mean only one thing.

They’re here.

Everyone knew who was coming from the east.

The Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League.

Two vast bands of outlaws who roamed the broad, blue rivers and mountains, yet still wanted a piece of the world itself.

And with them would come the forces of Dark Heaven.

An enemy army estimated at thirty thousand had finally arrived, following the long course of the Yangtze and pushing upstream against the Yellow River’s mighty current.

As the defenders fell silent before that reality, the two corpse sorcerers twisted their mouths into grins.

“You fools.”

“Do you understand now how shallow your little scheme was?”

The black-robed man and his companion made no effort to hide their delight.

They might have fallen for the defenders’ trap and ended up inside the fortress, but their forces were strong enough to overcome a three-to-one disadvantage.

Now tens of thousands of reinforcements had arrived at just the right time. They were almost embarrassed to remember how tense they’d been when they realized they were trapped.

The Lord of Heaven truly is helping us.

The black-robed man smiled faintly at the thought of the new heaven he served.

Then—

Step.

A group moved forward. They ought to have retreated at once, but instead, they came closer.

Of course. I knew the Kunlun fools would come out like this.

He spotted Cheongheoja and the Kunlun Disciples at the front and nodded to himself. Then several others popped out beside them, and he sighed.

"I've been meaning to ask… Who the hell are you people?"

If they'd looked ordinary, he wouldn't have given them a second thought. But even to a corpse sorcerer, the seven men and women made up a bizarre group.

Unfazed, they answered—or rather, the young man at their center spoke for them.

"Swift Wind Sword Hyuk Mujin. That's who I am."

The black-robed man's eyes widened.

"Swift Wind Sword?"

"That's right. So you've heard of—"

"Never heard of you."

"…Fine. Let me introduce myself again. I'm Hyuk Mujin, Vice Squad Leader of the Jin Dragon Squad. Though I'm taking a break from that for now."

"I haven't heard of that either. You might as well keep taking a break. Not that you'll be in this world after today."

"…Damn it. Then how about Hyuk Mujin, Vice Captain of the Fire Dragon Pavilion?"

This time, his companions' eyes widened.

"What? Since when? Do Vice Captains get extra pay?"

"Why would they choose Warrior Hyuk, of all people? Wasn't the position vacant?"

"I don't know. Honestly, I thought I was the best fit among us, but it seems I've been passed over because I'm from the unorthodox faction."

"Discrimination. Know. Delicious."

"Is this guy possessed by a glutton? In all my life, I've never met anyone more of a beggar than my Master."

"Oh, so your Master's a beggar too. No wonder. The moment I saw you, I thought you looked like you'd be good at begging for a living."

Greed and distrust they couldn't hide even now. Disappointment with the orthodox faction's rigged playing field. Endless appetite. And last of all, disrespect toward their Master and a steady stream of rudeness, as natural as breathing.

The black-robed man and his companion felt dizzy, as though they were staring into a true abyss. If not for Hyuk Mujin's answer, they might not have dared open their mouths.

But *Fire Dragon Pavilion* was familiar even to them. Everyone in Dark Heaven knew the name, regardless of rank, because of its connection to one particular man.

"The Fire Dragon Pavilion… You're Jin Taekyung's people?"

Hyuk Mujin gave his companions a cool look, then answered solemnly.

"That's right."

“Thanks, but strictly speaking, I’m with the Beggars’ Sect, not the Fire Dragon Pavilion.”

“Neither am I. I think.”

“…Could the two of you please keep your mouths shut? Please?”

The black-robed man looked them over again.

His duties hadn’t required him to know minor details like Swift Wind Sword or the Jin Dragon Squad, but he knew of the Fire Dragon Pavilion. Whenever Jin Taekyung had stood in the way of Dark Heaven’s grand plans, the Fire Dragon Pavilion had helped him, and its reputation had spread throughout the world.

He didn’t know why the one who looked most like a nobody was its Vice Captain. Still, he could see how this strange assortment had ended up together—and why they dared step forward in a situation like this.

“Birds of a feather flock together. You’ve gathered all the crazy men and women who don’t value their lives, just like your Pavilion Master.”

The black-robed man let out a short laugh.

The Fire Dragon Pavilion? He’d admit they had been a thorn in Dark Heaven’s side. But only because Jin Taekyung had been there.

Without him, the people before the black-robed man were merely young prodigies who had yet to come into their own. Puppies drunk on bravado and dreams of heroism, unable to tell when to advance and when to retreat.

“You spent your chance to run spouting nonsense. That’s why you’re going to die.”

What more was there to say to puppies whose teeth hadn’t even come in? An old, wounded beast quietly gathering its strength for one final struggle would be another matter.

There’s a Supreme Peak master among them. We still can’t let our guard down.

You worry too much. With the forces they have, they can’t get through the monsters to hurt us.

The black-robed man and his companion exchanged a silent glance. Watching Cheongheoja and the Kunlun Disciples aim their swords at them, they raised the ritual bells in their hands.

Tss-tss-tss-tss.

—Grrrrrr.

The thousand monsters growled in response to the waves from the bells.

Each was as large as two grown men put together. Their bodies were so tough, and healed so quickly, that nothing short of the level of injuring others with Sword Energy could leave a fatal wound. Ready to lunge, they fixed their eyes on the defenders.

Ssshhhh.

Beside them, the two Black Ghosts radiated a terrifying energy. Together, they gave off such overwhelming killing intent that even the defenders, resolved to fight to the death, instinctively stepped back.

Then, at last—

"Kill every last one of them."

At the cold command, the two corpse sorcerers swept their ritual bells through the air.

Tss-tss-tss-tss-tss.

The cursed sound waves, branded deep in the souls of the Black Ghosts and monsters, swept across the East Gate.

From beyond it came a quiet voice.

"Why would we run? We need to buy time by spouting whatever bullshit we can."

"…?"

"…?"

The black-robed man and his companion stopped without realizing it and blinked.

Was it because they couldn't understand the words of that nobody—Hyuk Mujin, who'd butted in out of habit and now claimed to be the Fire Dragon Pavilion's Vice Captain?

No.

The Black Ghosts were charging toward the defenders. The thousand monsters were not. Their limbs trembled as though something invisible held them in place.

I gave the command… So why?

Just as the question struck the two corpse sorcerers—

"Hey, can't you do it?"

Hyuk Mujin turned, and someone appeared behind him. Someone the two sorcerers had never expected to see here.

"I tried to focus as hard as I could. Hngh. But there's no way I can manage the Black Ghosts…"

"…!"

"…!"

His voice trailed off as their eyes met.

The two corpse sorcerers stared wide-eyed at their missing companion. They'd thought he would be dead by now. Ever since the Slaughter Saint had captured him at Qinghai Lake, he'd vanished without a trace.

Then they saw the dozen or so ritual bells in his hands. The bells had clearly belonged to the other corpse sorcerers who had died near Qinghai Lake. A sad smile spread across his bruised face.

"Sorry. That's how it went."

At that moment—

SHWEEEE!

A dazzling streak of light cut through the darkness and blocked the two Black Ghosts, who were racing forward like the wind alongside their ghost horse.

KWA-BOOM!

A deafening crash sent wind sweeping in every direction.

At the same time, through the thick cloud of dust, Cheongheoja and a wild-haired eccentric—no, a Great Sir—appeared and spoke to the Black Ghosts.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

“Couldn’t we talk this over first…? Oh, that was quite a good line.”

The two corpse sorcerers gritted their teeth. Amid the frantic fighting at the four walls, they had failed to notice another Supreme Peak master.

Perhaps what angered them most, though, was the insolent smile on that nobody’s face.

“If Captain—no, if the Pavilion Master were here, he’d say this.”

At Hyuk Mujin’s gesture, the captured corpse sorcerer shook the bells in both hands like mad.

Not one bell. More than ten.

Tss-tss-tss-tss!

The desperate jingle, driven by a stronger instinct to survive than at any other point in his life, pushed him one step beyond the limit of his usual ability.

In other words—

—Ghk, grrk?

He could not wrest complete control from the two corpse sorcerers who had been his companions yesterday and were his enemies today. But he could throw the thousand monsters into confusion.

—Kraaaagh!

—Gueeeeee!

Red eyes flashed wildly. Their killing intent lost its original target.

THOOM!

KRRRUNCH!

Freed from whatever had held them still, the monsters rampaged without distinguishing friend from foe. As the two corpse sorcerers froze at the sight, Hyuk Mujin’s words struck their ears like arrows.

“From now on, kill each other.”

Boooooo!

Over the horn sounding ever closer by the moment, the monsters’ ferocious roars mingled with the defenders’ shouts.

Chapter 1119

BOOOOM!

A deafening crash rang out, and the ground shook.

A thousand monsters rampaged without distinguishing friend from foe. Three thousand defenders stood ready to fight to the death. And four Supreme Peak masters flashed across the battlefield, clashing again and again.

The battle around the East Gate began in greater chaos and brutality than ever before.

Even the man who had designed and set this whole situation in motion could barely suppress his fear, despite putting all his strength into it.

—Kyaaaaa!

Hyuk Mujin watched the monsters charge, his eyes trembling as they roared.

They stood over one jang[3852] tall, with limbs as thick as the trunks of great trees. Their strength and speed far exceeded human limits. Their charge felt like a wave nothing could stop.

How has Captain fought so many of these things?

Jin Taekyung came to mind at once. He had always fought at the front, at the center of everyone else, risking his life.

And Mujin understood all over again why he had survived so many crises. He understood the enormous gap Taekyung had filled alone, and the weight of the responsibility he had carried.

So this is what it felt like.

Hyuk Mujin let out a ragged breath. His question would never reach Taekyung.

He was afraid. Afraid enough to throw down his sword and run as far as he could.

I would have done it before. No question.

But things had changed. The heir to a venerable fabric shop had become a martial artist of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, and he had come too far to turn and run.

The people who had gladly taken him along despite his lack of talent and skill had taught him too much. Jin Taekyung most of all.

“Never retreat.”

The words slipped past his trembling lips. They were less a command to the allies around him than a vow to himself.

They were also words the reckless Third Young Master—who now existed only in Mujin’s memories—had once said to him.

“Once you retreat… you’ll never be able to move forward again.”

So Hyuk Mujin did not retreat.

[3852] A jang is a Korean unit of length equal to ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

He suppressed the fear surging up from the depths of his chest, steadied his trembling sword tip, and charged at the monsters with all his might, roaring at the top of his lungs.

Just as Jin Taekyung had. Just as the other companions who had always believed in him did.

SHWEEEE!

A fierce wind whirled around him, wrapping his entire body.

Anyone who has experienced war agrees on one thing.

Battle was another word for madness, and war was all that madness gathered in one place. Keep cutting down the enemy before you and dodging the attacks that never stopped coming, and soon you would forget everything you knew.

Mujin clearly remembered hearing those words from an elderly man when he was a child.

He also remembered what the old man had told him when Mujin declared he would become a martial artist.

Hope is dazzling, but reality is cruel.

Yes. That was probably how he'd put it.

Now Mujin felt the truth of those words down to his bones.

THUD!

A heavy blow sent a shock through his entire body.

He had no time to react. Even if he had, he could not have dodged it completely. His strength had run out long ago.

KRRRUNCH!

How many times had the sky and ground turned over in his vision, bleached white? The first thing Hyuk Mujin felt after he was flung a long way was pain, great and small, sweeping through his body.

Blood came up with his cough and ran from the corner of his mouth.

His aching joints and twisted innards told him the truth: he was in terrible shape.

Damn… it.

Mujin gritted his teeth and swallowed the blood rising in his throat.

The old man's face had long since faded from his memory, but his words had not. Reality was cruel.

To Mujin, at least.

Only fifteen minutes, and look at me.

He could barely make his body move. A weak, self-mocking laugh escaped him.

Losing control had not made the monsters any less powerful. The creatures Dark Heaven had made were as strong as they were hideous.

Without the fine sword still in his hand, Mujin doubted he could have brought down twenty of them on his own.

Come to think of it, I only managed that much because of Captain.

He looked at the blade. Even after cutting through the monsters' tough bones and flesh, it had lost none of its keen edge.

The sword had been forged from part of the iron chain Jin Taekyung had given him after finally breaking free of his iron balls, just before the Star-Array Grand Banquet. It was the very chain the Fire Gate Clan had made to bind criminals of its own sect.

Only part of that chain had gone into the blade, but it contained a full four nyang[3853] of Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron. Its strength and sharpness made it worthy of being called a fine sword.

People who knew its origins sometimes teased Mujin that the sword was too good for him. He always bristled, but deep down, he knew they had a point. He had been stuck in the First Rate realm, making no progress. He owned a sword this precious only because Taekyung cared for his subordinate.

"Always snapping at people… and still making sure they have everything they need."

Mujin gave a faint, amused snort and slowly forced his screaming body upright.

Then he wrung out what strength remained and rushed the nearest enemy from behind.

Slice!

Perhaps it was exhaustion. His sword tip wavered at the last moment, but it still cut through his target's neck. This enemy, after all, was made of flesh and blood like Mujin.

SPLAT.

The headless fanatic staggered and fell into a pool of blood. Looking down at the body, Mujin felt his heart sink.

If only we'd had a little more strength. Just a little…

The strategy using the captured corpse sorcerer had worked. Most of the thousand monsters had fallen into confusion, and the three thousand defenders had charged into the chaos, driving their enemies back without regard for their own lives.

But the enemies they faced were not all inside the walls.

[3853] A nyang is a traditional Korean unit of weight equal to ten don. Four nyang is about 150 g (5.29 oz).

While the East Gate defenders gave everything they had to fighting the monsters, Dark Heaven's fanatics climbed over the walls using hooks and ladders. The moment they entered the battle, they tipped the balance away from the defenders.

Even now—

"…!"

"…!"

The eight-character creed, steeped in madness and all too familiar by now, rang out with a muffled force.

Mujin saw fanatics pouring down from the walls. He saw his exhausted allies, and the monsters beginning, one by one, to come back to their senses.

He heard the strong blare of a horn, now only a few hundred jang[3854] away. And he saw the face of someone who had recovered his smile as though nothing had happened.

"Your struggle ends here."

Mujin could not hear the words. But he could see the black-robed man's lips moving far away, before the tightly shut gate.

The man's companion had been killed by the monsters under his command as soon as the battle began. This sorcerer had managed to retain some control. Dozens of monsters still shielded him, and he was alive to enjoy a victory that, after one brief scare, seemed all but certain.

Yeah, maybe it really is over. But…

If Mujin ran away here, where would he ever win?

Hyuk Mujin muttered to himself as he staggered forward.

Forward, not back.

Whoooosh!

Even through his dulled senses, he felt the violent rush of air. A monster's fist, backed by hundreds of geun[3855] of force, came down toward the crown of his head. It would crush him in an instant.

Then—

Slice.

A sharp streak of Sword Energy came from somewhere and split the thick bone and flesh.

"It's too late. If you don't want to die, get back! Now!"

That face. That voice.

But Hyuk Mujin did not stop for Song Ilseom's warning. More precisely, he heard nothing at all.

[3854] A jang is a Korean unit of length equal to ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

[3855] A geun is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb); here it describes the force behind the blow.

At that moment, only one person's voice echoed in his ears like a hallucination.

"Mujin."

Jin Taekyung.

The man Mujin wanted to be like more than anyone—and the man who had shown him that he never could be.

Mujin moved his lips, stiff with dried blood, remembering their conversation before the battle.

"Yes. Go ahead."

SHWICK!

The hiss of something cutting through the air from his blind spot answered him instead. But Song Ilseom was not the only one who wanted Mujin to live.

THUNK!

A fanatic charging Mujin from the side arched backward like a bow.

Ju Hwaran drew her sword from the collapsing man's back. A dozen or so enemies who had been moving to stop Mujin changed direction and rushed her instead.

KRRRANG!

Steel rang out amid the unending screams and shouts. Mujin walked as though entranced along the path they had opened wider for him.

He left everything around him behind and listened to the voice still ringing in his ears.

"If something goes wrong—I mean, on the slightest chance that it does…"

Taekyung had been different then. There had been no laughter in his face, no trace of mischief.

"At least die where I can see you."

And then, facing his subordinate, who had gone rigid, he'd forced a strained smile.

"Of course, that won't happen. But if it did, I'd be able to avenge you, wouldn't I?"

It was the first time Taekyung had said anything like that.

Through all the dangers they had survived together, he had only ever told Mujin one of two things.

Run.

Or make sure you survive.

Whatever danger came, Taekyung was always the one at the center, the one out in front. He had never hesitated to take the lead in this damn gamble they played with their lives.

To protect a subordinate, a companion, his master—or someone he had never even met.

Mujin could not help respecting him. And he could not help giving him the answer he wanted.

"Of course we'll win this time, too. But yes. If it comes to that, I promise I will."

Perhaps that was when Mujin had first begun quietly turning the word *death* over in his mind. When he had truly prepared himself to die.

But…

If I'm going to die, I won't die for nothing.

He forced up a corner of his blood-crusted mouth and brought down the sword in his clenched hand.

Slice!

The two fanatics blocking his path fell at the same time, as though they had planned it. So easily that it looked like a scene from a play.

Then, at the fanatics who had stopped short, eyes wide at this unexpected turn, a fierce torrent of saber energy swept in.

KRRRUNCH!

Beneath a fountain of blood came a cold voice, strangely at odds with the ferocity of the attack.

"Go. If that's your choice… I'll open the way."

That was all.

Sama Pyo plunged among the enemy without hesitation. A strong hand caught Mujin's shoulder as he stumbled.

"Hyuk Mu…"

Mujin quietly shook his head at Taishan.

He knew what Taishan wanted to say. Killing the black-robed corpse sorcerer, now just twenty jang[3856] away, would not change who won this battle.

But Taekyung would have said that even if they died, the trade would be worth it.

"Hur…ry."

It took nearly all Mujin's strength to get the word out.

Taishan watched him silently, then tightened his grip. And with one short sentence, he used all his strength to send Mujin flying far away.

"Let's go eat something good later, Vice Captain."

SHWEEEE!

Wind tore past Mujin's body. He answered Taishan in his heart.

We will. We'll eat until we burst.

And then the black-robed man's wide eyes were right in front of him.

Slice!

A flash carrying the last of Mujin's strength swept across the corpse sorcerer's neck.

[3856] A jang is a Korean unit of length equal to ten cheok, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

In a battle where thousands—tens of thousands—were locked together, one person's death might mean nothing.

But the single head rising into the air was enough to change the battle around the East Gate.

Thud. Clatter.

The head fell. The ritual bell dropped from the dead man's loosened hand.

At the same instant, the roughly three hundred monsters that had survived the terrible melee and were still rampaging stopped moving.

"…!"

"…!"

For one stretched-thin instant, silence fell.

Some stared wide-eyed. Some smiled faintly.

And someone else, who had made all of this possible, felt a shiver run down his spine as he silently looked at the head at his feet.

No—not at the head. At the clean cut across the corpse sorcerer's neck.

At the trace of what people under heaven called Sword Energy.

It wasn't the sword…

It had happened for only an instant. Perhaps, with his mind already half gone, he had imagined it.

That did not matter. He had finally done it with his own strength.

He had proved, at least a little, why he'd been able to defeat twenty monsters, and why he deserved to stand alongside companions who were far more than he could ever hope to deserve.

And just as a feeble smile formed on Hyuk Mujin's lips—

BOOOOM!

A blast like the sky splitting open shook heaven and earth. An immense wave of qi flung open the tightly shut gate.

Wooooooong.

The air trembled.

Through the faint darkness, a shadow wreathed in an aura as immense as a mountain leaned toward Hyuk Mujin, standing alone before the gate.

"What is your name?"

In that moment, Mujin knew this was where his life would end. He would not be able to keep the promise he had made to Taekyung before the battle.

"Fire Dragon Pavilion… No. Swift Wind Sword Hyuk Mujin."

He answered more calmly than he ever had before.

Then, with the shadow's quiet reply, he felt an immense force drive into his chest.

"I'll remember it."

POOM!

Hyuk Mujin’s vision plunged into darkness.

Chapter 1120

Boom!

The low sound of air being torn apart rang out, and the whole world seemed to stop.

At least, that was how it felt to the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion who saw a palm strike, launched at lightning speed, hit Hyuk Mujin in the chest.

And then—

Splatter.

As Hyuk Mujin's body crumpled, scattering dark-red blood, the world that had stopped began to move again.

"No!"

Taishan's eyes were bloodshot. The muscles across his body bulged as if they might burst.

At the unbelievable sight before him, he let out a thunderous roar and charged toward the gate.

He forgot his exhaustion. He cast aside his fear.

Like an enraged bull, Taishan swung his two-section staff with all his strength and pressed forward.

Whoooosh! Wham!

Each time the furious wind rose, brains flew and bones shattered like powder.

Fanatics had taken the place of the monsters, frozen like statues at the death of the corpse sorcerer. They tried to block his path, but none could easily stop Taishan in his rage.

No—more accurately, they couldn't stop *them*.

KRRRUNCH!

A fierce rush of saber energy tore through the space, and severed limbs flew in every direction.

Amid the swirling spray of blood, Sama Pyo's eyes—usually so composed—blazed with blue fire.

And someone else plunged into the dozens of fanatics closing in around Sama Pyo, heedless of their fallen comrades.

SHWEEEE!

Song Ilseom's narrow-bladed sword shot through the air in swift, economical movements, each one utterly cruel.

Even the epithet Soul-Chasing Guest seemed inadequate.

Stab! Stab-stab!

Song Ilseom stabbed and twisted at every opening.

With the most efficient movements, he dealt his enemies certain pain and death.

Blood burst from a terrible scream and splashed across his face. Blades rained down indiscriminately from every direction, leaving cuts large and small across his body. But his tightly pressed lips didn't tremble.

The blood flowing through Song Ilseom's veins came from an illustrious family. But what had made him the Soul-Chasing Guest was blood shed on the battlefield.

He had once left the path of the wandering martial artist, which he'd walked all his life to repay the debt of an earlier generation. Now he was throwing his life away to repay a comrade's blood debt.

He gave himself over to pure rage, without a thought for the cost.

And Song Ilseom wasn't the only one who felt it.

"How dare you…!"

"You bastards are lower than this beggar!"

Sssshing! Slice!

Ju Hwaran, Gung Gibang, and the thousand defenders who had barely survived gritted their teeth and forced themselves to their feet.

Hope that they could win?

They'd long since erased it from their hearts.

The monsters had stopped moving, but fanatics remained—several times as many. Worse, tens of thousands of enemy reinforcements had appeared.

But hope wasn't the only thing that could move people.

In that dark, bottomless despair, they had seen it clearly:

Hyuk Mujin, refusing to lose his dignity until the very last moment before he fell.

Fire Dragon Pavilion… No.

Before an enemy they could not possibly defeat, his spirit had not bent.

Swift Wind Sword Hyuk Mujin.

CLANG-CLANG-CLANG!

At last, a thousand blades began to shine again, rippling like a wave.

The defenders clamped their hands over severed arms and slashed-open bellies. They bit their tongues to suppress their pain and fear, gripped their weapons, and stood.

With all their strength, they shouted what might be their last words—the final proof that they had existed in this world.

"Knife-and-Dagger Hero So Gyuhyeok is here!"

"Swift Blade Shakes the Heavens Mu Cheol is here too!"

"Figures the orthodox faction would have such fancy titles. I'm Black-Killing Sword Jo Hyeok, you bastards!"

Masters of the orthodox faction, the unorthodox faction, and those who belonged somewhere between the two.

Their roots, their branches, and the fruit they bore were different. But the great cause they sought to protect was the same.

“Destroy the Demonic Path and restore Heaven.”

Destroy the Demonic Path and set the heavens right.

An old Daoist[3857] murmured the four characters they had once shouted until they were spitting blood, back when they fought a hundred thousand followers of the Demonic Path. He tightened his grip on his sword.

Slice.

A body split into dozens of pieces along a streak of white light and scattered.

The Black Ghost had finally met its true end. The old Daoist[3858] turned away, and Cheongheoja’s voice rang out, carrying the force of his internal energy.

“I miss those days. The time when you and I were ‘us.‘ Don’t you?”

In Cheongheoja’s eyes, steeped in sorrow and anger, a huge figure stood before the ruined gate in the distance.

“Seafaring King Pa Ryun.”

The next moment—

“You haven’t changed, Cheongheoja.”

With a heavy voice that brushed over Hyuk Mujin’s fallen head, the master of the long, vast Yangtze strode out beneath the faint moonlight.

Two more unwelcome guests emerged from behind his imposing frame.

One was a mysterious figure dressed in black from head to toe. The other, a slight old man standing beside him, had a familiar face.

“It’s been a long time, Cheongheoja.”

At the greeting, Cheongheoja’s gaze turned cold.

“Right. You were there too. Green Forest Battle King Tae Gunak.”

“Such a sharp edge to your words. Last time we met, I believe you called me a fellow Daoist,[3859] not ‘you.‘”

“Those days will never return. Not after the irrevocable choices some people made.”

Tae Gunak looked around, his brow furrowing slightly.

“I’m sorry things came to this. I mean that.”

“You mean that…”

Cheongheoja murmured the words hollowly, then drew up every last bit of his remaining internal energy.

[3857] A Daoist follows Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition centered on the Dao, or Way.

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[3859] A Daoist follows Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition centered on the Dao, or Way.

Hummm.

As if sensing that his master's end was near, the treasured sword that had been with him all his life trembled.

Not far away, Great Sir was still struggling against Black Ghost. But Cheongheoja's senses and energy had already focused entirely on the unwelcome guests guarding the gate.

He had to bring down more than the two giants who divided the world's dark-path forces between them.

There was also the mysterious man in black. Instinct told Cheongheoja he was no weaker than either of them.

He must be one of Dark Heaven's key figures. But who?

The question crossed his mind, but Cheongheoja could only smile bitterly.

Worry was ultimately a luxury for those who survived.

For an old Daoist[3860] who had to face three Supreme Peak masters alone, there was no point in worrying any further.

All he could do was resolve to meet his end without shame before those remarkable young people, still advancing as they cut down their enemies.

"Come, you thieves of the world. I am Cheongheoja of Kunlun."

The old Daoist's[3861] eyes flashed, colder than ever.

"Let's finish this quickly."

A quiet voice reached every ear.

Rumble.

The black-robed man stepped forward, and immense qi began to churn around him.

Cheongheoja, charging with all his strength. Great Sir, fleeing in haste from the Black Ghost's sword. The Fire Dragon Pavilion members fighting their way through the fanatics, and the thousand defenders following them in their final stand.

Every one of them stared wide-eyed, trembling at the eruption of power that filled their vision as though it would be the last thing they ever saw.

SHWAAAA!

A single line—impossible to block, impossible even to see clearly—cut across the world.

[3860] A Daoist follows Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition centered on the Dao, or Way.

[3861] A Daoist follows Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition centered on the Dao, or Way.

"…!"

Why had his body suddenly gone rigid?

Where had this enormous rock come from, pressing down on his chest?

Jin Taekyung couldn't tell what had caused it or why.

No—he didn't want to know.

The moment he found out what this sudden feeling of dread meant, he felt the last thread barely holding him together might snap.

But despite that, Jin Taekyung's gaze toward somewhere in the east, hidden behind enemies and buildings, had begun to tremble.

This is…

His vision was blurred as though by mist, his senses dull as an axe waiting for winter. His whole body sagged like waterlogged cotton.

Even so, he could faintly hear and feel it.

The enormous blast that had rung out far to the east. The steep surge of power.

It pointed to only one thing.

The East Gate… has fallen.

He wanted to deny it, to tell himself it couldn't possibly be true. But it was no use.

Unlike the fire raging in his chest, his mind had gone cold. It faced the reality coming toward him head-on.

It's them. It has to be.

Pa Ryun, the Alliance Leader of the Yangtze River Channel League.

And Tae Gunak, the Alliance Leader of the Green Forest Alliance—Pa Ryun's equal and lifelong rival.

The two giants who divided the world's dark-path forces between them had finally reached the battlefield.

And they'd brought an army of thirty thousand.

…Then that means—

Unable to finish the thought, Jin Taekyung raised his hazy eyes and looked around.

People leaned against the low walls of the Inner City, gasping for breath amid countless bodies and pools of blood scattered in every direction.

Some of those who had retreated from the three sides other than the East Gate had familiar faces. Others had not appeared at all.

Why?

Jin Taekyung wondered in a daze.

Why hadn't they returned yet?

He already knew the answer. Still, he asked himself again.

Right. So that's how it ended.

A weak laugh escaped him.

He thought of the faces he would never see again.

He felt the presence of tens of thousands of enemies surrounding the Inner City, and of the monster leading them.

KWA-BOOOOM!

With a tremendous crash, the Inner City crumbled.

Chapter 1121

Regardless of a wall's height, size, or durability, its mere existence made a huge difference in a siege.

Even the shabbiest wall was still a wall.

Xining's Inner City had been built with street fighting against outside invaders in mind. Its walls might not compare to those of the Outer City, but they still offered a considerable advantage.

It should have, anyway.

KWA-BOOOOM!

It began and ended in an instant.

All because of one man.

No—one monster.

Rumble.

The Inner City wall crumbled with a roar like a scream, raising a thick cloud of dust. Watching it fall, the Blood Lord laughed wildly.

He prided himself on having gained power beyond human limits. To him, the sight was laughable.

They should have been scattering in every direction, running for their lives. Instead, they'd fled to the Inner City?

"Did you think a pile of rocks like that could stop me?"

With a low mutter, the Blood Lord raised the Red Blade once more.

Shhhhh!

A blood-red flash surged along the blade.

A massive half-moon of Force took shape in an instant, about to tear across the space before him—

"Stop!"

An urgent voice rang out.

But even as someone appeared to stop him, the Blood Lord brought the Red Blade down without hesitation.

WHOOOSH!

The space turned red.

In a flash like a bolt of lightning, the Force crossed dozens of jang[3862] and sank into the dust cloud.

No—it swallowed the cloud whole.

Its ferocity could only be called monstrous.

KRRRUNCH!

[3862] A jang is a traditional length equal to ten ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

As the crash and tremor shook heaven and earth, the Blood Lord smiled. Then he turned toward the uninvited guest who had dared to stop him.

“You’re late. You should’ve said something sooner. I might’ve been able to stop just in time.”

The Blood Lord sounded almost casual. The Grand Sorceress’s gaze turned cold.

“What have you done?”

“What does it look like?”

He shrugged and gestured with his chin toward the distant cloud of dust.

“Crushing their last hope. Making sure they won’t even want to resist anymore.”

“You…”

Her voice trailed off. She stared at the still-smiling Blood Lord, unable to continue. Then she asked calmly about the one thing that mattered most: whether a certain person was still alive.

“So he’s still safe, isn’t he?”

“Safe? Better than fine. Look at me. Can’t you feel this power?”

The Blood Lord spread his arms with the innocent pride of a child showing something off to a parent. A chill settled in the Grand Sorceress’s chest.

He was different.

He had changed.

Everything about him was different from usual.

His pupils were completely blood-red. An unprecedented aura flowed naturally from his grotesque body, as though human and monster had been fused together. But the greatest change lay elsewhere.

Madness.

The Grand Sorceress could sense it now: a bottomless madness whose depth and intensity she could not begin to fathom.

Instinct also told her she must never let him know she had noticed.

“Cut the pointless nonsense. You know better than anyone that isn’t what I meant.”

“That hurts. I didn’t know there was something you cared about more than the well-being of a comrade in the same boat.”

“Since when were we so close?”

“Well, if you put it like that, I have nothing to say. Fine.”

The Blood Lord let out an exaggerated sigh.

“Jin Taekyung is still alive. Probably.”

“Probably?”

“Then let me correct that to *definitely*. There’s no way those old monsters in there couldn’t protect one little brat.”

Even to the Grand Sorceress, it didn’t sound like an unreasonable guess.

Just fifteen minutes earlier, the defenders had retreated from the walls on all three sides except the East Gate and gathered in the Inner City. Among them were the Bow Saint, the Slaughter Saint, and the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

They'd all suffered serious injuries while withdrawing to the Inner City, but even so, their wounds shouldn't have been severe enough to prevent them from keeping Jin Taekyung safe.

As if to prove the Blood Lord right, familiar faces appeared beyond the thinning dust cloud.

And among them was the most important person of all—the one who absolutely could not die.

"…!"

The Slaughter Saint and the Bow Saint were pale with exhaustion and internal injuries. Jeok Cheongang looked worse than either of them.

But the Grand Sorceress barely saw them now.

She saw only one person.

Jin Taekyung.

The moment she spotted him, she let out the breath she had been holding.

There was no mistaking him. He was drenched in blood from head to toe, but he was alive.

He could barely stand, using a white-glowing spear as a cane while Cheongpung supported him. For the Grand Sorceress, that was enough.

She had Magic—the mysterious power the Lord of Heaven had given her.

Still, Jin Taekyung's condition looked so grave she could sense his precarious state even from this far away.

I have to take him to that person. As soon as possible.

His injuries might be beyond even Magic's power to heal completely.

The anxious Grand Sorceress was about to recite a teleportation spell silently when—

"What's the rush?"

"…!"

The Blood Lord's low whisper came from behind her. Her eyes widened before she could stop them.

How?

If the foundation of martial arts was the accumulation of energy, Magic depended on attunement to it. That made her more sensitive than anyone to its fluctuations.

Yet the Blood Lord had taken a position behind her without her seeing or sensing him. He stood there smiling like a predator with its prey already in its mouth.

“The more I think about it, the more interesting Magic seems. Traveling thousands—tens of thousands—of ri[3863] in the blink of an eye… Even saving someone who’s half dead. Am I right?”

His hot breath touched the back of her neck. The Grand Sorceress spoke through clenched teeth.

“I already told you. Cut the pointless nonsense.”

“Nonsense?”

The Blood Lord gave a short laugh and licked his lips with his red tongue.

“Not this time, I’m afraid. I don’t want to let prey I’ve already caught escape like that.”

Realizing what he meant, the Grand Sorceress gritted her teeth.

“Blood Lord, you’ve finally gone mad.”

“That’s strange. I could’ve sworn you always called me a madman.”

“You dare go against that person’s will…?”

After a brief silence, the Blood Lord answered with a bright smile.

At last, he had cast off his mask and shackles. He was freer—and stronger—than ever.

“Why not? Just this once.”

At that moment—

Slice!

A streak of red flashed. The Grand Sorceress’s hazy figure appeared three jang[3864] away.

Then—

SPLAAASH!

Her body staggered, spraying blood, before collapsing like a puppet with its strings cut.

Splat.

That was the end.

Her body lay motionless in a pool of blood. Her eyes remained wide open, without a trace of life in them.

“I wasn’t planning to kill her… Oh, well. Can’t be helped.”

The Blood Lord muttered to himself and looked around.

Countless eyes stared at him in the sudden silence. Tens of thousands of fanatics surrounded the Inner City without a gap in their lines, watching the unexpected scene with eyes wide.

This time, even they could not hide their agitation.

[3863] In this Chinese setting, a ri corresponds to a Chinese li, about 500 m (0.311 mi).

[3864] A jang is a traditional length equal to ten ja, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

The Blood Lord addressed them calmly, choosing the shortest and surest method—one possible only in Dark Heaven.

"By the command of the great Lord of Heaven, I have executed the apostate. From now on, I will command the entire army."

"…!"

"…!"

"Kill every last one of them."

The order broke the heavy silence.

Rumble!

With a roar that shook heaven and earth, tens of thousands of fanatics charged toward the Inner City.

To punish the wicked heretics who dared oppose the Lord of Heaven—the living god and sole absolute ruler.

The fanatics surged forward like a giant wave. The Blood Lord laughed aloud and began to walk.

He was going to take the life of the one man he had longed to kill.

"Jin Taekyung—!"

The monster's roar, imbued with an unprecedented aura, rang across the battlefield and swallowed it whole.

"…!"

"…!"

The air trembled. Sound was muffled in my ears.

Shouts and screams burst without pause from every direction. The bone-chilling clang of steel engulfed the battlefield.

But through the chaos and my fading senses, I could still feel it:

The warmth radiating from the people fighting countless enemies to protect me.

At the same time, I heard the monster's roar, full of joy and madness.

Jin Taekyung.

Right. That was my name.

The name I had been given at birth.

In two different worlds, I existed as both one person and two.

And maybe today was the last moment I'd been given.

I have to go.

I didn't know where I found the strength.

My organs must have been twisted, my Eight Extraordinary Meridians torn to shreds. With the mere handful of internal energy I had left, I couldn't do anything.

Even so, I shook off Cheongpung’s support and staggered forward as if in a trance.

Slice!

A stray blade grazed my shoulder.

Blood flowed—blood I hadn’t even known was still there—but I felt no pain as I reached out.

CRACK.

The fanatic’s gleaming eyes widened in pain.

He instinctively tried to wrench his wrist from my grasp with all his strength, but a surge of scorching heat reached him first and engulfed him.

BOOM!

To someone else, it might have felt like flames hot enough to burn them alive. To me, it felt like the warmest thing in the world.

Maybe it was because of who had saved me.

“El…der.”

Squeezing out every last bit of my voice, I grabbed Jeok Cheongang’s shoulder and whispered.

“A path. Please open a path for me.”

“…!”

Chapter 1122

With the collapsed walls at their backs, the defenders fought more fiercely and more valiantly than ever.

After surviving against impossible odds and retreating to the Inner City, they numbered a little over five thousand.

Compared to the tens of thousands of fanatics blackening the land on every side, they were a mere handful. Yet the last-ditch defenders didn't give an inch.

No—they couldn't.

Behind them, beyond the rubble of the fallen walls, countless civilians trembled before the threat of death drawing closer by the second.

But having nowhere left to retreat didn't mean they could advance.

KRRRUNCH!

Flesh split, revealing white bone. Amid the red mist that swirled over the battlefield at the moment of impact, anguished screams and shouts rang out, muffled and dull.

"Graaaagh!"

"Hold the line! We have to hold—!"

Stab!

An axe blade cleaved through the crown of his head, cutting off the shout.

The man who crumpled had been a Peak master renowned as a hero throughout Qinghai for decades. But in this horrific melee, amid all this death, none of that meant anything.

And he wasn't the only one.

The Sect Leader of a school. The Family Head of a household surrounded by relatives.

A young man whose downy cheeks hadn't even lost their softness.

The moment the fanatics' blind blades swept them up, they fell as nothing more than lumps of meat.

CRUNCH! Stab-stab-stab!

Perhaps the outcome of this desperate final battle had been decided before it even began.

The defenders had long since pushed past the limits of exhaustion.

Surviving this long in today's battle was proof of their strength. But what lay before them couldn't be overcome by sheer will.

The energy they had left. Their numbers.

They lacked everything. Desperately.

The dead rolled limply across the ground. Those still alive could only tremble on instinct as they watched the advancing enemy trample over the bodies of their fallen comrades.

Fear and anger gripped them, along with the helplessness of being unable to do anything.

Perhaps that was why, as their bodies and hearts—and the whole world around them—seemed to sink into pitch-black darkness, the flame someone kindled shone all the brighter.

Fwoosh—BOOM!

The air caught fire. Heat like the sun evaporated the rain and swallowed the fanatics whole.

At the heart of the fierce flames surging forward stood a giant of fire, his burning eyes flashing.

“Who dares!”

With a furious roar, Jeok Cheongang, the Fire King, swept his sleeve.

The flames, whipped up by a fierce wind, melted steel and burned the fanatics’ flesh and bones.

“Stand in our way?!”

Jeok Cheongang had always called himself “this old man,” but not this time.

He wasn’t walking alone anymore.

Now, they walked together.

Along the perilous, steep path to the brink of death that Jeok Cheongang had always been forced to walk alone, there was now someone at his side—a man who had become both a part of him and his whole world.

“Don’t retreat! Don’t be afraid!”

Supporting Jin Taekyung as he staggered, Jeok Cheongang burned the enemies rushing in from every direction and shouted with all his might.

Blades he would normally have scoffed at and dodged grazed his body. Every time he summoned his internal energy, pain blazed through his tangled acupoints. None of that mattered to him now.

“Open a path!”

It was a request from Jin Taekyung, his one and only Disciple.

A reckless request. One that might truly be his last.

But the old Master couldn’t refuse his Disciple, already standing at death’s door.

And Jeok Cheongang wasn’t the only one willing to grant it.

Slice!

Dozens of heads flew into the air in a dazzling flash.

Jeok Cheongang swallowed the blood that suddenly surged into his mouth and watched with a faint smile.

“Took you long enough. You’re slow as hell.”

At the familiar reproach, the Slaughter Saint spoke, his face pale as a sheet.

He, too, had suffered serious injuries fighting to hold back the Grand Sorceress and the Black Ghosts during the retreat to the Inner City.

“I couldn’t see the patient, so I went looking. Figured I’d drag him back by the collar.”

“And what do you intend to do?”

SHWICK!

The Slaughter Saint answered by bringing down his small knife.

The strike was ghostly in its speed and precision. The fanatics rushing in to fill the momentary gap crumpled like bundles of straw.

Just as his heart had when he saw Taekyung’s condition.

“Before it’s too late…I’ll take the lead.”

At the Slaughter Saint’s quiet reply, something tightened in Jeok Cheongang’s chest.

Perhaps the man could escape this battlefield right now. He was the greatest assassin of all time.

That was why they called him the Slaughter Saint.

Yet Jeok Cheongang gritted his teeth against the weight pressing down on his heart.

Before it’s too late.

That was what he’d said. Clear as day.

Jeok Cheongang knew instinctively that the words hadn’t come from the Slaughter Saint as an assassin, but from the Divine Physician. And that his answer held not a glimmer of hope, but despair.

He’s going to die.

A cruel truth too hard to believe, too hard to accept.

Jeok Cheongang stared blankly at Jin Taekyung, limp in his grasp as if unconscious. Then he clenched his fist.

There were no choices left for them now.

All they could do was give everything they had and kindle one last flame—perhaps their final one.

Even now, that flame was slowly growing larger and hotter.

SHWAAAA!

Force suddenly shot out from somewhere and spread across the space.

Unlike the Slaughter Saint’s Force, so keen it seemed it could cut you just by looking at it, this web of Force felt as free as the wind. It wrapped around the enemies.

Calmly. Gently.

Then it struck with enough destructive power to wipe away that fleeting impression.

Slice—SPLAAASH!

A fountain of blood burst into the air.

Among the enemies crumpling to the ground, the Bow Saint appeared. Following the movement of her fingers, the broken bowstaff—split in two amid the fierce battle at the West Gate—moved with blinding speed.

KRRRUNCH!

It had lost its original shape, but her bow had always been made to come apart and serve as a pair of curved swords.

Without a word, the Bow Saint swept through the fanatics like a storm. Close behind her, another familiar face appeared.

“Benefactor!”

Despite his urgent shout, Cheongpung’s sword technique flowed as gracefully as a painter’s brush across white paper.

SHSHSHK!

A handful of purple Force, the color of sunset, sketched out flowers.

The dozens of plum blossoms seemed beautiful—until they touched the fanatics. Then they turned an even deeper red and bloomed in a glorious spray.

“Why’d you have to come along too…?”

Before the Slaughter Saint could stop Cheongpung from plunging deep into enemy lines to join this perilous undertaking, a roar from far away swallowed the battlefield.

“…!”

“…!”

If a sound could take the shape of a giant, would it look like this?

The roar was so immense it shook even the eardrums of someone whose hearing had already burst. And there was a desperate, almost spiteful edge to it.

Everyone who turned toward its source stared wide-eyed.

Jeok Cheongang and Cheongpung, injured themselves, supporting Jin Taekyung as they fought off their enemies.

The Slaughter Saint and Bow Saint, realizing that the enemy reinforcements who had finally taken the East Gate had arrived.

And one man walking slowly toward them, an overwhelming aura pouring from him.

No—a monster.

“That’s…”

His words trailed off.

The Blood Lord stared toward the source of the roar, an indescribable look on his face. Then he burst into laughter.

“Pfft—hahahahaha!”

His booming laughter had no place on a battlefield covered in a sea of corpses and blood.

But the Blood Lord didn’t care. He laughed like a madman, bending over and clutching his stomach as if he’d never heard or seen anything funnier in his life.

Then, as if he hadn’t laughed at all, he lifted his head, his expression cold, and looked at the countless people approaching from far away beneath shouts that seemed to pierce the heavens.

They were weaker and more insignificant than any enemy he had faced so far. That only made those damn moths flying into the flame more infuriating.

“What kind of lunatics are these…?”

The Blood Lord meant it. He could think of no other explanation for the absurd sight reflected in his blood-red eyes.

But no matter how he questioned it or thought it over, he couldn’t find an answer.

No—even if the Blood Lord gained the power of true immortality, he could never understand it.

The old, the powerless, the very young—people born to spend their lives being trampled and trembling in fear—were risking their lives to protect someone else. He couldn’t even imagine it.

And yet they were there.

They shouted with set faces and trembling voices, caught between desperate resolve and fear they couldn’t quite shake. They gripped crude bamboo spears and rusty axes with all their strength.

They had spent their lives yielding to fate. Now they defied it to help those who had staked their own fates on protecting them.

Countless civilians, seeking for the first time in their lives to protect someone beyond their own families.

They were here.

Today. Right here.

“How—dare you!”

The monster’s roar, charged with power beyond anything before it, crushed the civilians’ seemingly endless shouts.

“…up.”

With a faint voice only a handful of people could hear, Jin Taekyung forced his eyelids open in his Master’s arms and struggled to speak.

“Shut up already…you fucking bastard.”

Chapter 1123

“You…!”

Hearing that familiar voice tremble with agitation, I let out the breath I’d been holding.

I blinked slowly and swallowed the blood pooled in my mouth.

It was a strange feeling, unlike anything I’d ever experienced.

I felt hazy, as if I were trapped in a dream I could never escape. And yet, at the same time, everything around me came through with perfect clarity.

As for what this unfamiliar sensation was, the System gave me a clear answer, as it always did.

In its uniquely kind and cruel way.

Beep.

SYSTEM

Status Effect: **Final Rally has been applied.**

Final rally.

Like sunlight blazing just before sunset, it was the last flame to burn at the darkening edge of a life.

So this is what it feels like.

The thought came to me suddenly.

I thought of the final moments of those I’d brought down with my own two hands—and those I’d desperately tried to hold on to, only to lose them anyway.

All the countless emotions I’d glimpsed in them.

At last, I felt as though I could understand them all.

I understood something else, too. Unlike them, who had waited for death as it slowly drew near, I was the kind of fool who had no choice but to run toward it.

Ding.

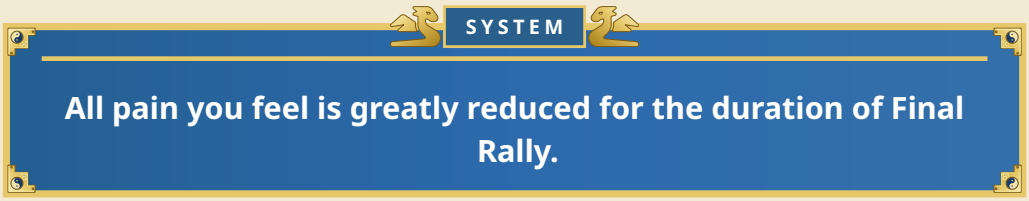
SYSTEM

Final Rally is an act of divine mercy, an expression of human will, and a candle by which you may reflect on the life you have lived. Though its flame burns only briefly, that moment of light will shine so brightly that even death may be forgotten.

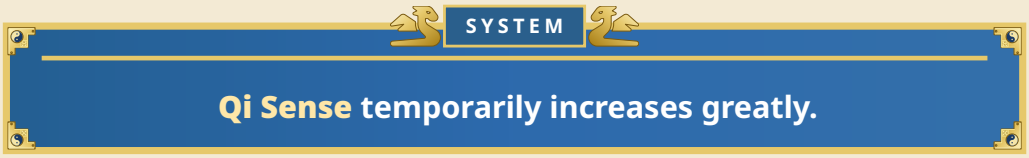
This time, it wasn’t the cold, harsh warning tone.

A familiar, clear chime rang in my ears, rousing my body and mind from their endless plunge into darkness.

Just as the System had said, it was a light bright enough to make me forget even death.



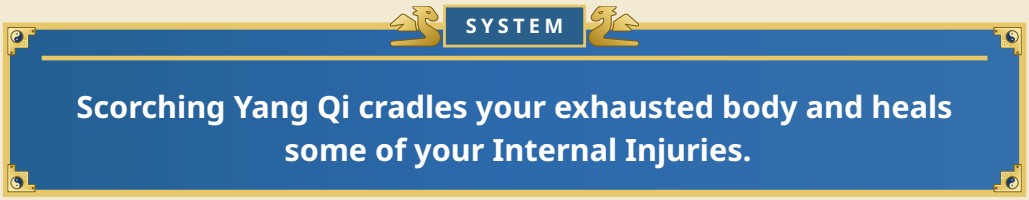
My body stopped trembling under the pain and death closing in by the second.



A spark caught in the ashes of my cooling mind.

Fwoosh.

Sudden warmth seeped into my back, and the spark swelled into a flame.



Two flames could not coexist.

Sooner or later, they would collide and destroy each other.

But if they came from the same root, they were one flame to begin with.

Just like the person who, despite suffering severe Internal Injuries of his own, had shared his qi with me without hesitation.

“What are you waiting for?”

His face was as pale as paper. Wounds large and small covered his body, and his frame trembled.

But Jeok Cheongang was smiling at me.

He was trying to hold back both his joy that his Disciple had regained a little strength and his sorrow at what that meant.

“Come on. Let’s go. Together.”

At that moment—

Ding.

SYSTEM

A sudden Quest, A Candle in the Wind, or a Flame, has been generated!
Death awaits you. You cannot refuse this Quest!
Time Limit: 9 minutes, 59 seconds

Time began to flow again. I gripped White Flame tightly and took a step forward.

Into the nightmare that wasn't over yet.

No—toward a reality worse than any nightmare.

I'll change it. I have to.

If this had been my fight alone, I might have given up already.

I might have leaned my exhausted body against a pile of corpses, looked back on the time I'd left behind, and waited for death to slowly descend.

But—

SHWICK!

I wasn't alone anymore.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Dazzling light-flames swallowed the enemies whole.

Amid the reddish, overheated earth and the shimmering haze that warped the air, a giant of fire roared.

At the same time, the Slaughter Saint, the Bow Saint, Cheongpung, and the last of the devoted defenders advanced.

Countless civilians followed behind them like a wave, no longer shouting out of desperation but calling a name none of us had expected.

"Charge! Charge! Protect the Marquis of Shangshan!"

"…!"

The great shout shook the battlefield and reached my ears. A jolt like lightning shot up my spine.

They said they would protect me.

Me, of all people.

Those people with neither a scrap of internal energy nor a proper weapon, gripping sickles and pickaxes in their hands.

They were risking their lives for me—the man who hadn't even managed to protect his own people.

Right. In the end, I couldn't protect you.

The beloved faces I would never see again flashed through my mind, and I shot toward the fanatics.

SHWIIK!

My toes. My waist. My shoulder. My arms and wrists.

My body followed movements etched into instinct through countless repetitions and real battles, splitting the raging wind and rain.

Slice!

A single, cool cutting sound crossed the air.

At the same time, more than ten pairs of eyes flew wide open.

The fanatics stared at me in disbelief, clutching their slit throats as they crumpled to the ground.

White Flame's spearhead, trailing a faint heat, was slower and weaker than it had ever been. But for some reason, the enemies waiting in its path couldn't react in time.

Neither could those surging forward to fill the gaps left by their dead comrades.

Stab! Crack!

I stabbed through everything in my way, pulled my spear free, and twisted it.

My vision was still hazy, but my senses were sharper than ever.

So were the faces and voices that flickered past, one by one, through the thickening mist of blood.

"I'll join you. Just make sure the danger pay is generous."

A pair of fierce eyes, and the willow-leaf saber he always kept close.

But despite his rough appearance, Song Ilseom had always been a reliable comrade and a good person to me.

He complained about the danger and the extra pay on every mission, yet he always fought in the most dangerous places.

He'd left behind the path he'd walked his whole life to protect someone. I was sure he'd kept that vow until his final moments.

He must have. The Song Ilseom I knew would have.

There was more to a person than what you saw.

That was true of a wandering martial artist others might have seen as nothing but rough and uncouth. It was true, too, of the two unorthodox faction members I'd unexpectedly formed ties with.

Am I too late?

That day in Gansu, when a battle like this one had raged, Sama Pyo had returned from staying with his father through his final moments and asked me that question.

I'd answered without hesitation.

No. You came right on time.

I'd meant it. There hadn't been a trace of a lie in my answer.

Even if he lost his way while wrestling with his choices and took a long detour, Sama Pyo was the sort of person who would find his way back to the right path in the end.

No.

He was that kind of friend.

The words echoed endlessly somewhere deep inside me, and I moved as if entranced.

SHWICK!

Like Song Ilseom, I rolled through a pool of blood to evade blades flying at me from every direction.

Slice!

Like Sama Pyo, I ended my enemies' lives by the cruelest, surest means.

KRRRUNCH!

Like someone else who wasn't here, I swept through everything in my way with an overwhelming aura as immense as Taishan.

Taishan believes in Pavilion Master! Likes him second best in the world, after Lord!

I pressed forward.

Voices rang like hallucinations amid flying blood and screams.

Familiar faces appeared, one after another, over the enemies collapsing like bundles of straw.

"Would you like to take a walk?"

The memories rose like mist and passed like wind.

The Fire Courtyard of the Yongbong Escort Bureau, shrouded in darkness, and the full moon, unusually bright and large that night.

"Great Hero Jin."

Her lively voice and light, dancing steps, buoyed by drink.

"Do you think…I can do it?"

And the tears in her eyes that none of it could hide.

"Can I really do it?"

I remembered it all vividly.

Every bit of it.

How I'd made a pointless fuss about the brightness of the moon, then fallen silent at her unexpected question.

Even the moment I'd looked into her tear-filled eyes and spoken.

"It's all right if you can't do it well. You don't have to force yourself."

That night, I hadn't been looking at the moon.

"Wouldn't that be enough, Young Lady Ju?"

I'd been staring blankly at her eyes, brighter than the full moon and curved like a crescent.

I'd never imagined a day like today would come—or that pitch-black Force would come rushing toward me as it was now.

WHOOOOOSH!

"Get out of the way!"

When had I gotten this far?

Jeok Cheongang's urgent shout rang out behind me, deep in enemy lines, and a terrible whooshing sound swallowed the noise around us.

But I didn't flinch.

More precisely, I didn't have even that much reason left.

I only faced the two streams of energy darkening my already hazy vision. They were so murky they hardly seemed alive at all.

Not with my eyes, but with my senses.

No—with my heart.

And in the gap between moments slowed to a crawl, I thrust out my spear.

SHWICK!

White Flame's spearhead, wreathed in a faint blaze, cut through the air.

It pierced space, the darkness beyond it, and a single point.

Fwoosh!

"…!"

"…!"

The two streams of Force, which had seemed ready to swallow everything without a trace, scattered helplessly. I felt the air tremble all around me.

Destruction? A clash?

No.

The only word for what had just happened was *shattering*.

It was so inexplicable that even I, the one who'd done it, couldn't understand it.

So perfectly shattered that it enraged even the dead who had just fired Force at me.

—JIN. TAE. KYUNG!

The last two Black Ghosts cried out in unison and charged.

A ghostly horse leaped across the dozen or so jang[3865] of open air in an instant, casting its shadow over me. With its blood-red eyes flashing, the now-enlarged Force came crashing down.

KWA-BOOOOOOM!

The rushing blast was violent enough to shake even my already-burst eardrums.

[3865] A *jang* is a traditional unit of length equal to ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

But I wasn't the only one in its path.

KWAANG! RUMBLE!

In the blink of an eye, four streaks of light tangled in midair and swelled.

The compressed air exploded, and the earth overturned beneath the tremendous force.

At the heart of it were two superhumans who had rushed to save me.

Stab! Crack!

The Slaughter Saint's short knife and ox-hair needles, and the two curved swords clenched in the Bow Saint's hands, pierced and sliced through the Black Ghosts at lightning speed.

The two Saints gritted their teeth, faces ashen, wringing out what little strength they had left. The Black Ghosts, meanwhile, refused to fall.

They recovered from mortal wounds and even severed limbs, rising again after dozens of deaths.

Wooooong.

The air trembled.

Countless overlapping spells bolstered the Black Ghosts' ability to heal and gave them still greater strength and speed.

Enough to face two of the Three Saints, who had fought more fiercely than anyone and were now pushed to their absolute limits.

"Go! Hurry!"

The Slaughter Saint's urgent shout pierced my ears. The Bow Saint's tired, lowered gaze touched my cheek, as if telling me to prove I was the one who'd been chosen.

Or that this wasn't where I was supposed to die.

Right. I can't fall here.

I staggered forward, leaving them behind.

Following Jeok Cheongang and Cheongpung as they opened a path, I cut down the enemies looming through my dreamlike haze, again and again.

I thought of a promise to one person that could never be kept now.

Of the moment I hadn't been able to bring myself to tell someone who had become my greatest memory in this world to run away.

"I'm Hyuk Mujin, Captain of the Gatekeepers of the great Jin Family of Taiyuan. State your identity and purpose for visiting… What? A pleasure house?"

"Third Young Master, I may be a low-ranking Captain, but let me say one thing."

We'd met as enemies who couldn't seem to shake each other.

"A scouting squad? Why me, Third Young Master…?"

"I'll follow your orders. Captain—no, Captain, sir."

Before long, the two of us had fallen into step.

"Now, now, Captain. What's there to worry about when you've got me?"

"Your heart! Your right arm! Trust Hyuk Mujin!"

"...Even so, isn't your little toe a bit much?"

Then we'd become inseparable.

So close that, at some point, being apart no longer felt right.

When I couldn't see him, I missed him. When he was away, I worried about him.

My most trusted friend and subordinate.

That guy—Hyuk Mujin—had died.

In the end, I hadn't even seen where he'd died or who had killed him.

Even if some miracle saved him, I'll never see him again.

The last promise I'd made to him would never be fulfilled.

I would die before it could be.

Because I'd have to leave behind the people I'd wanted to protect—or the people waiting somewhere for me, desperate for my return—and set off down a long road from which there was no coming back.

But...!

I gritted my teeth and let out the breath I'd been holding.

I swung my spear, rekindling the dying flame without pause.

Trampling the corpses piling up with each step and the blood spurting into the air, I moved as one with the people protecting me.

Toward the last, the only path left for the living and the dead alike.

Toward the blood-red eyes I could sense clearly even through my hazy vision.

KRRRUNCH!

The fanatics' flesh and bones broke apart beneath the spearhead I brought down on instinct.

Beyond that fierce storm of blood stood a monster steeped in blood and madness.

"You should be running for your life, yet you've come to me of your own accord. I hardly know how to thank you."

The Blood Lord, at last standing before me again, smiled broadly.

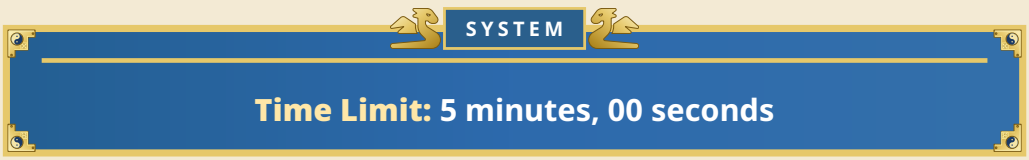
More precisely, he smiled at Jeok Cheongang and Cheongpung, both exhausted beyond measure, and at me standing between them.

"Now, it's time for you to die."

Maybe he was right.

But—

Beep.



Not yet.

Chapter 1124

Beep.

SYSTEM

Time Limit: 5 minutes, 00 seconds

The second hand of a clock granted to only one person on this vast battlefield began to move.

Flash.

Space split apart.

It was erased, shattered.

And at its center, four figures hurtled toward one another with all their might.

More precisely, one monster and the three humans standing against it.

Among them was Jin Taekyung.

SHWAAK!

A horrifyingly low whistle of air pierced his ears.

A strike that seemed capable of splitting a mountain, faster than sound itself.

The Red Blade came down at an angle, swift and fierce in equal measure.

Could Jin Taekyung have followed that movement even in his usual condition?

Even if he had, he wouldn't have dared meet the enormous Force coiling around the blade head-on.

But his senses, honed sharper than ever at the edge of death, were guiding his still-warm body toward a path of survival.

Rustle.

The wind stopped. Time slowed.

In Jin Taekyung's eyes, hazy as a clouded sky, the blood-red blade and its blazing Force passed barely an inch from his face.

Slice!

Following the strike's path, the ground split like tofu mere inches from him.

The wind pressure whipped around like a blade and raked his body, but Jin Taekyung had already forgotten pain. As if entranced, he thrust out his spear.

SHWAAK!

The spearhead pierced straight through space.

At the same time, Jeok Cheongang's Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist and Cheongpung's sword cleaved through the wind.

FWOOSH, SHWISH-SHWISH-SHWISH!

Two streams of flame surged forward as one, while sunset-violet Force scattered like flower petals.

Their renown might differ, but each of the three Supreme Peak masters could make the entire Murim tremble at the sound of his name. Together, they launched a perfect combined attack.

But waiting for them was a monster that had already far surpassed the limits of humanity.

HWAASH!

Enormous qi boiled up in an instant.

At the same time, the Blood Lord's hands, now free of the hilt, struck through space like a bolt of lightning.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Two palms, faster than sound itself.

With a roar as if the sky had split, a blood-red flash erupted around the Blood Lord and swept in every direction.

An overwhelming, destructive force that made no distinction between friend and foe.

RUMBLE, RUMBLE…!

A deep reverberation spread through the devastated space.

It swept past the fanatics' corpses, scattered in countless chunks of flesh, and reached the three men staggering as they steadied themselves.

"They survived that?"

The Blood Lord muttered despite himself.

He had put tremendous power into that strike—poured a third of his strength into a single attack.

Enough to erase every living thing within a radius of over ten jang[3866] and turn the area into a hellscape where only death remained.

Of course, the outcome wasn't entirely beyond what he'd expected.

No matter how grievously wounded and bloodied they were, a beast was still a beast.

Especially when even the weakest beast among them was called the Huashan Divine Dragon.

No—perhaps this was for the best.

If he'd killed them all with that last strike, he might have been left feeling empty.

"No. Not like this. Not so easily."

The Blood Lord let out a low laugh and took a step forward.

Rustle.

[3866] A *jang* is ten *ja*, or about 3.03 m (9.94 ft). Over ten jang is over 30.3 m (99.4 ft).

Something felt wrong.

He raised his hand to see what it was, and his gaze turned cold.

Blood.

Beads welled up from a shallow split in his skin—too slight to even call a wound—and ran across his palm.

The very hand that had just met someone's attack head-on.

"This is…"

The Blood Lord trailed off and slowly lifted his head.

And saw him.

One man, covered in blood from head to toe, struggling to catch his breath.

His face was so pale he could have collapsed at any moment, yet his eyes still held a flame that hadn't died out.

Jin Taekyung.

The Blood Lord ran his red tongue over his lips.

How had this happened?

He'd been sure he had blocked the attack.

None of their strikes could have broken the Palm Force gathered in his hands.

And yet—

"Yes. This is how it should be. You ought to manage at least this much."

The Blood Lord murmured softly, almost to himself.

The light that had dimmed in his eyes flared to life, and his wavering lips curled into a gentle smile.

At this moment, he was truly enjoying himself.

Carelessness? Fear of what might happen?

He'd felt none of that from the start.

He had simply been certain.

Certain that he could hunt the prey before him, whether it was a powerless rabbit or a beast hiding its fangs.

Though it had been only a single exchange, the Blood Lord had realized once again just how immense the power within him was at this moment.

And how boundless.

Squelch.

As the monster stepped forward, the pool of blood at his feet, spread out like a small lake, swirled and rushed toward him.

SHWAAAAA!

The Blood Lord greedily swallowed the blood. Intoxicated by the strength surging through him anew, the monster shot through space like a flash of light.

Drip.

A single drop of blood fell behind him.

The Blood Lord's confidence was no arrogance.

He moved faster than anyone else on the battlefield, and the immense blood-red Force bursting from his Red Blade was enough to make anyone who saw it think of the word *unprecedented*.

At least at this moment.

He was the strongest predator on this vast battlefield, an absolute being no one could oppose.

With even the two giants among the Three Saints pinned down by the enemies' fierce counterattack, he was powerful enough to crush the three Supreme Peak masters—each already seriously injured—in an instant.

Jin Taekyung knew that better than anyone. Which was why he couldn't understand what was happening.

SHWEEEE!

Why—

KRRRCH!

Why was that terrifying Force, powerful enough to split a mountain—

SHWAAK!

Why was the Blood Lord's movement, seemingly faster than wind, sound, even light—

WHOOOOSH!

Missing him by a hair every time, every single moment?

Why couldn't it touch him?

"You—!"

Jin Taekyung didn't hear the monster's voice echoing through the blade-sharp wind.

No. More precisely, he couldn't hear it.

Amid the flashes that continually washed across his hazy vision, he simply kept moving as if entranced.

Slice!

He brought his advancing foot back to where it had been and ducked his head. The blood-red Force passed overhead.

A nearly flawless dodge, without a moment's hesitation.

Jin Taekyung himself didn't know how he had evaded such a swift, ferocious strike. He didn't know why he'd moved that way, either.

He just felt he had to.

It all seemed perfectly natural.

Like the sun rising in the east each morning, or water flowing downhill.

Like a duel whose every move had been carefully arranged in advance.

But that was true only for Jin Taekyung.

Rustle, SHWEEEE!

The Red Blade was descending toward the crown of his head when it abruptly changed direction.

KWAANG!

With a single deafening crash, Cheongpung, who had rushed in to attack from the blind spot, dropped to one knee and spat up blood.

Above him, the Red Blade had wiped away the path of the Thirty-Six Plum Blossom Swords in an instant. It crashed down like lightning and bore upon his sword with the weight of ten thousand geun.[3867]

CRACK.

The violet Force faded rapidly, and hairline fractures spread across the blade like a spiderweb.

As Cheongpung swallowed blood and summoned all his strength, the Blood Lord's dark-red light poured down on him.

"You dare, you little—!"

The monster's earlier delight had turned to anger.

Why? How?

With martial prowess this immense, and Jin Taekyung clearly dying, why couldn't he finish this simple fight whose outcome was so certain?

And even when victory was all but decided, why did that damned brat before him keep resisting to the end?

Just as he had on that day at Mount Song, when he'd inflicted a humiliation that was like a brand upon the Blood Lord.

"Fine. I'll kill you first."

The Blood Lord spat out the words. The blood-red Force swelled and dug into Cheongpung's blade.

Then—

HWAASH!

Heat swept in from behind him. The Blood Lord released the hilt without hesitation and thrust out a fist.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Two fists collided in midair.

[3867] A Korean *geun* is 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg (about 13,200 lb).

White light-flames and blood-red Force charged at each other, each trying to devour the other.

But the difference in their power was already clear. Through the thick heat haze, the Blood Lord bared his teeth at Jeok Cheongang.

“Get lost, old man.”

BOOM!

Blood-red Force swallowed the flames. With an explosion, Jeok Cheongang was sent flying helplessly and rolled across the ground.

Right where someone had been standing just moments before.

…What?

The realization came in an instant.

An alarm rang in the Blood Lord’s mind, and a current of air crossed the space between them.

Fwoosh.

A whistle of air so low and faint it raised goose bumps.

In time slowed to a crawl, the Blood Lord turned. Jin Taekyung filled his blood-red eyes, thrusting out his spear with a hazy gaze.

“…!”

The Blood Lord couldn’t even get out the word *How?*

Nor could he think how he, overwhelmingly powerful as he was, had lost track of the presence of a bloodied wretch sinking deeper into death with every passing moment.

Jin Taekyung was no different.

Now.

It was as if someone else, someone he didn’t know, were whispering in his ear.

His vision was clouded white, and he couldn’t see a thing.

Time was running out. A horrible weariness—and an even stronger feeling of death—was seeping into his body.

Shhk.

Jin Taekyung thrust out his spear smoothly.

The shouts and screams of friend and foe, ringing out without pause even now. The cold clang of steel. The sound of a trumpet, now drawing close.

Even the palm the Blood Lord thrust out on instinct.

Nothing could stop him.

Leaving it all behind, as if it had been decided from the beginning, Jin Taekyung let the flames deep inside his body flow toward a single point.

Pshk.

The spearhead, carrying a faint heat, pierced the palm wrapped in Force and drove on through.

Past that very hand, whose wound, for some reason, still hadn’t healed.

KRRRCH!

The monster’s eyes flew wide, bulging as they filled with shock.

Chapter 1125

KRRRCH!

At the ghastly sound of flesh tearing, the Blood Lord felt as though the world had stopped.

Ah.

Hot. Distant.

His vision wavered. The noise around him seemed impossibly far away.

Everything felt so unfamiliar that he wondered if all that had happened until now had been a dream.

If not for the terrible heat scorching his flesh and bones, he might truly have believed it.

No.

If not for the face he could see beyond the acrid smoke and shimmering haze of the flames.

Cough.

Fresh blood spilled past his lips.

Through pain so fierce it turned his vision white, the Blood Lord coughed up blood mixed with bits of his innards and looked at the young man before him.

The reckless young moth, now joined to him by a single spear.

He parted his blood-soaked lips.

“How?”

It was a short question, but there was much behind the genuine confusion in his eyes. Jin Taekyung answered.

“I don’t know either.”

“What?”

“I just… knew. It felt natural.”

His voice astonishingly calm, Jin Taekyung went on.

“Every move you’d make. And what I had to do.”

“…!”

“That’s all.”

The Blood Lord’s eyes widened before he even realized it.

Because of the pain burning through him?

No.

The accursed spearhead had pierced his palm and driven deep into his body, spreading heat through him. Compared to the shock he felt now, that was nothing.

He knew? Everything I’d do?

A moment ago, he would have scoffed at such absurd words.

His power had grown beyond its limits, and the gulf between them was so vast that even the word *possibility* had become meaningless.

But—

He isn't lying. He isn't boasting.

The moment their eyes met, the Blood Lord understood instinctively.

A truth unbearably cruel to him.

And the fact that he had been trying desperately to deny it.

"So there was no point in asking in the first place."

"Yeah."

Jin Taekyung gave a small nod, then added faintly,

"At least in that moment, I was stronger than you."

Hearing his enemy say what he could no longer deny sent a shiver down the Blood Lord's spine.

Countless emotions swept through him, overwhelming even the pain.

Bitter defeat. Fear of something he could not comprehend. And something entirely at odds with both.

Deep relief and joy.

With his whole body, he knew he had made the right choice.

Lord of Heaven, my revered master. Are you watching? Can you hear me?

The Blood Lord looked up. He whispered toward his own heaven, hidden behind the unceasing rain and dark clouds.

My choice was never wrong.

The truth was, anxiety had been stirring in a corner of his heart.

Unwavering loyalty was not the only reason he had decided to eliminate Jin Taekyung.

He'd been disappointed. Resentful.

His master seemed to spare no thought for the servants who gave their lives in his service.

And, absurdly, he'd been jealous of Jin Taekyung, who received something close to affection from that same master.

So he'd wanted to kill him.

He'd told himself he was removing an obstacle that kept standing in Dark Heaven's way, hiding his reasons behind the word *loyalty*.

But now he no longer had to.

Here, today, Jin Taekyung had proved for himself why he had to die.

And die he would.

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. I'll admit it. You deserve to be called a Divine Dragon."

The Blood Lord whispered the words to Jin Taekyung without a trace of falsehood.

If anything, *Divine Dragon* seemed inadequate.

Even at death's door, Jin Taekyung had fallen into a Trance and drawn closer to a higher enlightenment. Remembering it sent a chill through the Blood Lord.

"Yes, you were right. In that moment, you were terrifyingly strong. Strong enough that even I couldn't stop you."

He didn't know what profound enlightenment Jin Taekyung had gained.

He didn't know how he could fight so fiercely with his life hanging by a thread.

Or how a spearhead carrying no more than a handful of qi had broken through his formidable Force.

But—

"None of that matters."

By then, the Blood Lord was smiling.

Wearing a bright smile no defeated man could have worn, he grasped the spearhead buried deep inside him.

The spearhead of White Flame, lodged a handspan from his heart.

Squish. Crack.

Blood burst out with a ghastly sound of tearing flesh.

The Blood Lord pulled the spearhead free with a hand wrapped in dense Palm Force and muttered,

"I thought I was dead. In that moment, I truly did."

Jin Taekyung's final attack, thrust with all his strength, had been a strike the Blood Lord could not have stopped.

If Jin Taekyung's internal energy hadn't run dry at just that moment—

If the spearhead hadn't lost power and veered off course because of it—the Blood Lord would have died.

But he hadn't.

This is Heaven's will.

Joy welled up from deep within him.

The heavens above had chosen him, not Jin Taekyung.

Not that paltry heaven you believe in. This is the will of the true Heaven I serve!

At that moment, a lightning-like thrill made him forget his pain. The Blood Lord pulled his pierced hand free and twisted the spear shaft.

SHWIK—KRRRCH!

The shaft spun violently, its force impossible to resist.

White Flame snapped through the cloth its owner had tied tightly around it so he would not lose his beloved weapon. Then it tore free of Jin Taekyung's grasp, leaving his hand covered in blood.

Splatter.

Unable to withstand the force, Jin Taekyung was driven backward. He fell, unable even to keep himself upright.

The Blood Lord stepped toward him without hesitation.

Or rather, he tried to.

Before he could, another Divine Dragon—one raised on the slopes of Huashan, not beside a pond—charged in with a roar.

“No!”

SHWAAAAK!

Sunset spread through the darkness. Force bloomed along the sword’s cracked blade and scattered into thirty-six petals.

The strike was beautiful enough to draw gasps from anyone who saw it.

But the desperation behind it was greater than ever, making it all the more heartbreaking.

FWOOM!

The blood-red Force that filled the space was strong enough to cut down not just the petals, but an entire forest.

KWA-BOOOOM!

The earth shook with a deafening crash.

Beyond a cloud of dust that even the pounding rain could not settle, a figure staggered upright and stood before the fallen Jin Taekyung.

Not one figure, but two.

“Where do you think you’re going? *Cough.*”

Jeok Cheongang and Cheongpung stood in his way again, both covered in blood. The Blood Lord’s red eyes darkened.

“Mount Beimang.”

He raised the spear that now belonged to him at an angle and added,

“Of course, you’re the ones going there.”

Hummm.

The spearhead, parted from its master, let out a sorrowful hum.

Shhhhh.

I stared blankly at the dark sky stretching beyond the endless rain.

This is Heaven’s will.

The Blood Lord’s voice still echoed in my ears.

Not that paltry heaven you believe in. This is the will of the true Heaven I serve!

Remembering the joy in those blood-red eyes, I muttered to myself,

Yeah. Maybe it is.

I'd done everything I could.

No—all of us had fought with everything we had.

Until there was nothing left to give.

Until I couldn't even feel regret or anger.

But…

I never followed the will of Heaven.

Quietly, desperately, I struggled.

Squish.

With my crushed, broken hand, I gripped a clod of dark red earth mixed with blood as hard as I could and pushed myself up.

I had to. There was no other choice.

For the people even now collapsing, their blood scattering around them.

They were the paltry heaven the Blood Lord had mocked.

BOOM!

A fierce crack split the air.

Through my blurred vision, I saw Jeok Cheongang stagger and drop to one knee. Cheongpung was flung away like a cannonball and rolled across the ground.

And the monster, having torn down every obstacle in his way, came toward me.

Splash.

One step, then another.

His blood-red gaze grew clearer as the distance closed. I put every bit of strength I had into getting up.

Like a baby whose earliest movements I couldn't remember, I rolled onto my front, planted my hands and knees on the ground, and somehow hauled my swaying body to its feet.

By then, the Blood Lord was close enough that his eyes seemed to burn red as the sun. The moment I met them—

Inventory open. Summon.

From the boundless storehouse granted to me alone in this vast world, I drew a finely sharpened dagger and thrust it forward.

At the same time, a low, mocking laugh reached my ears.

"As expected."

Crack.

I felt no pain, but the sound told me enough.

The Blood Lord had caught my wrist in a flash and crushed it beyond any hope of recovery.

But he wasn't the only one who could predict his opponent.

Slip. Tap.

Ignoring the pain erased by my final rally, I kicked the dagger's hilt with my toe as it fell from my grasp.

Thud.

"…!"

With a cool, tearing sound, the dagger sank deep into flesh.

The Blood Lord's eyes flew wide. He looked down at the blade buried in his shin and licked his lips.

"Impressive. Truly impressive. But that is why…"

Without a moment's hesitation, he whipped his remaining leg like a lash.

"I can never let you live."

KRRRCH!

White bone burst through mangled flesh.

Having crippled one of my arms and both my legs, the Blood Lord shot out a hand like lightning and seized my throat.

Crack.

Bones shifted, and my vision darkened.

As I gasped for breath, his low voice reached my ears.

"We've been bound by a long, ill-fated connection, Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung."

At that moment—

FWOOSH.

Like a last candle burning as a life flashed before it, my vision turned white even as it fell into pitch-black darkness.

No.

Perhaps the color was deeper and redder than sunset.

Slash.

Chapter 1126

It was a low, faint sound—one no one would have noticed under ordinary circumstances.

Nothing beside the ceaseless roar of battle shaking heaven and earth.

Just the sound of wind brushing past somewhere.

But to someone else, it struck like a sudden storm, an unstoppable bolt of lightning.

Shhk.

The cold slicing sound reached the Blood Lord's ears a moment late. His lips parted before he knew it.

"…Huh?"

The joy that had filled his eyes moments ago gave way to confusion. In his blood-red pupils, a fine line appeared across his arm.

Before he could make sense of it, blood welled through his skin and raced along the line.

PSSSHHH!

A fountain of blood shot into the air. The Blood Lord could only stare, eyes wide, as his arm fell away in a spray of crimson.

Beside the severed arm collapsed the man who had barely escaped death.

Splatter!

The moment Jin Taekyung's already-crippled body crumpled to the ground, time began to move again.

Yet even with the man he had wanted so desperately to kill lying at his feet, the Blood Lord couldn't move.

And he wasn't the only one who had stopped.

Taekyung's master, reaching a trembling hand toward his disciple, who lay in a deep pool of blood facing death.

The Bow Saint and the Slaughter Saint, who had finally shaken off countless enemies, including the two Black Ghosts, and were racing toward him with not an instant to spare.

Cheongpung, driving the blade of his sword—now only a handspan[3868] long—deep into the ground to force himself upright.

They all felt it. At the same time, they saw it.

Beyond the curtain of wind and rain, someone's figure wavered into view.

Shhhhh.

[3868] A handspan is the distance between the thumb and little finger of an outstretched hand. It varies by person but is roughly 20 cm (8 in).

Through the endless rain walked a black-clad figure. At a movement of his fingertips, an ancient silver blade swept down.

Shhhk.

In that instant, the world split apart.

The rain and wind.

The air and qi within them.

And the darkness.

SHWAAK!

The dazzling flash that filled their eyes was deeper than sunset and as brilliant as dawn.

Just like that day a year ago, burned into the Blood Lord's mind like a brand.

This is…

In a moment so brief it seemed time had been cut into slivers, the Blood Lord froze, eyes wide. Someone's presence flashed through his mind.

A name that could not—and must not—appear here today.

A man without peer when it came to the sword, known as the Number One Sword Under Heaven.

A man whose realm had reached the heavens, known as the Sword Saint.

"Mae Jonghak—!"

The name burst from the Blood Lord's lips like a scream.

FWOOSH!

Within the swelling flash, dozens of strands of purple Force bloomed.

Tap.

Beneath their dazzling petals, a hand suddenly reached out and touched the Blood Lord's foot.

No—

KRAK!

It seized the monster's ankle with all its strength as he tried to turn away.

Just like that day when Mount Song was stained with blood.

"…!"

In the monster's widened, blood-red eyes, a young man's faintly smiling face was reflected.

And the purple flash that had finally reached him.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Being unable to feel pain is both a curse and a reason for despair.

Pain is proof that you're alive and breathing.

For a living person to feel none means death is near.

But that is only one side of it.

For someone who has watched death draw close and accepted it deep in their heart, the absence of pain might be one last blessing instead.

No—it must be.

At least right now, Jin Taekyung was more grateful than ever that he couldn't feel pain.

Both his legs were crushed. One arm was shattered. Yet he could still move, and that made him so happy he could have cried.

KRAK!

Where had that strength come from?

Even Taekyung didn't know.

He had reached out as if bewitched, as though something were controlling him. Somehow, the strength in the only one of his four limbs that wasn't broken had been enough to stop the monster in his tracks.

I got… him.

Taekyung smiled.

Through his blurred vision, he raised the corners of his mouth at the Blood Lord staring down at him.

And then—

KWA-BOOOOM!

A tremendous roar battered his ears. A dreadful explosion of power shook everything around him.

Yet inside, he was as calm as a deserted lakeshore.

This is enough.

The flash swallowed his vision as he murmured to himself.

Yes. It was enough.

He had done all he could. He had no regrets.

No—he couldn't allow himself even one.

If any regret remained, he wouldn't be able to leave in peace. He would call out the names of the family and friends he wanted to see, blame himself for failing to see things through, and bawl like a child.

But now it was all right.

Mae Jonghak had come.

With the Martial God—the heavens—gone, the Sword Saint Mae Jonghak was the highest star in the sky and the greatest under heaven in this era.

Taekyung had an inkling of how Mae Jonghak could have appeared here when he should have been protecting the Central Plains as Alliance Leader. He let the thought go.

He was simply grateful for the hope that this unexpected savior could defeat the monster and save everyone who remained.

Thank goodness. Really.

With that hollow thought swallowed deep in his heart, Taekyung's eyelids began to close.

CRACK!

Amid the fading roar and flash, a hand shot out like lightning and seized his throat.

Drip. Drip.

Something hot and sticky fell onto his forehead.

Above him, the monster's blood-red eyes still burned.

"How dare… *cough*… the likes of you…"

The Blood Lord growled like a wounded beast.

He had to swallow mouthfuls of blood just to speak. Wounds deep enough to expose bone covered his body. Yet he was still alive.

He lifted his dying prey like a trophy and bared his bloodstained teeth again.

"Did you think you could defeat me? Me, who inherited the Lord of Heaven's mighty power?"

Just then, a faint voice escaped Taekyung's lips, which were turning white under the grip around his throat.

"Yeah. You son of a bitch."

"…What?"

"I think he can."

Taekyung smiled faintly at the Blood Lord, who stared at him in silence. At those blood-red pupils, now trembling ever so slightly.

And he understood. Anger wasn't the only thing behind that tremor.

"You're scared, aren't you? Of what's happening."

"…You."

"Yeah. Even a bastard like you has to be scared. That's why you're pulling this cheap hostage stunt."

Grind.

The Blood Lord gritted his teeth without realizing it.

A cheap hostage stunt?

Bullshit.

It had to be bullshit.

So why couldn't he answer? Why did his grip loosen instead?

Taekyung's mocking voice reached his ears.

“Look around. Then you’ll know whether you’re the hunter right now—or the prey.”

The Blood Lord didn’t answer. He didn’t look around, either.

He couldn’t bring himself to.

He didn’t want to admit that five Supreme Peak masters, led by the Sword Saint, had surrounded him. Or that he had seized Taekyung to hold them back, if only for a moment, and buy himself time.

At this rate… I’ll die.

He could feel it against his skin. He knew it instinctively.

That cruel truth, impossible to believe and unbearable to accept, pierced him to the core.

Why?

He couldn’t understand how the power bestowed on him by his great master had left him in an instant.

Gone. All of it.

The healing that might as well have been immortality. The qi that had surged endlessly from blood.

Only the strength left over after that power vanished kept him standing.

But I will not die.

The Blood Lord bit his lip, trembling with shame.

He thought of the last hope he had left—the final hammer blow that would end this terrible, immense battle.

“Watch closely. See who survives here today.”

He spat the words at Taekyung, who was still smiling.

Bwoooooo!

A powerful trumpet call shook the battlefield. At last, the hope he had waited for appeared.

Rrrrrumble!

Countless footsteps shook the earth. Enormous flags waved high, as though they might pierce the sky.

Tens of thousands of troops in all manner of dress marched beneath them. Everyone could clearly see the words on the two flags flying overhead.

Yangtze River Channel League.

And Green Forest Alliance.

“…!”

“…!”

A wave of unseen shock swept across the battlefield.

“Ah. Ahhh…”

The suicide squad and civilians, who had fought the invaders with everything they had, froze like statues.

"Lord of Heaven!"

The Dark Heaven fanatics, who had held the battle at a stalemate despite a counterattack backed by overwhelming numbers, began chanting the eight-character invocation praising the Lord of Heaven as if entranced.

The Blood Lord watched with joy in his eyes.

"In heaven and on earth, all demons bow…!"

A shiver ran down his spine. He turned to Taekyung, eager to see the despair on his face as soon as possible—and for as long as possible.

Then he realized something was wrong.

His last hope might have been despair all along.

"A meeting when the Yellow River runs clear."

"What… did you say?"

"Someone sent me a letter once. Said she'd wait for the Yellow River to run clear. That we'd meet again then."

Taekyung remembered the letter Wolhwa had sent while he was staying in Gansu.

A single line he had long since forgotten.

> Hoping that someday we can meet when the Yellow River runs clear,
> Wolhwa.

Wearing his brightest smile yet, Taekyung lifted a trembling hand and pointed east.

"Looks like this is the moment."

More precisely, he pointed to another enormous flag slowly rising behind the two at the head of the army.

Through rain falling hard enough to clear the Yellow River, three characters came into view.

Murim Alliance.

"…!"

The Blood Lord stood frozen, eyes wide.

Taekyung made his final move.

KRAK!

The Blood Lord couldn't stop Taekyung's teeth from sinking into his neck like a beast's.

Through the overwhelming pain, the world slowly tilted.

Splatter.

The monster, stripped of all the power he had been granted, finally crashed into the pool of blood.

Chapter 1127

It all began in an instant—and ended in one.

But a moment that flashed past like lightning could feel like ten years to someone caught inside it.

KWA-DRRRK!

With a grisly sound of flesh tearing, the Blood Lord's body shuddered.

Hot. Distant.

That was all. That was everything.

How?

The Blood Lord couldn't understand.

Why hadn't the palm strike he'd thrown on instinct brought his opponent down before those beastlike teeth sank into his neck?

Why was the Murim Alliance's banner flying above those damn bandits?

And as he felt his body, no longer under his control, being pushed helplessly backward, he muttered to himself:

Well, it doesn't matter anymore.

Splatter.

Sticky blood sprayed. Time, which had stopped, began to move again.

Lying in a pool of blood as broad as a pond, the Blood Lord looked up at the sky filling his vision.

Was it always this dark?

In truth, he already knew the answer.

The world was unchanged. Only he had changed.

The monster's pupils were still as red as blood, but even now, his fading gaze could no longer make out light from shadow.

A world gone entirely black.

Beyond it, all the Blood Lord could feel was the rain pouring down without pause and the chill of blood soaking his body.

No. That wasn't all.

Someone's voice echoed in his ears.

"You… still listening, you son of a bitch?"

Jin Taekyung.

It was him.

He spat out the flesh and blood filling his mouth and smiled, though he was panting as if he might collapse at any moment. Even forcing out one syllable at a time looked like a struggle.

"I can hear it. Clear as day."

The Blood Lord couldn't answer.

He could only swallow the bloody phlegm rising in his throat and listen to the roar shaking heaven and earth.

—Destroy the Demonic Path and restore Heaven!

Destroy demons and set Heaven right.

It was the old Murim Alliance's banner, the vow it had upheld to the very end—and the hoof that had trampled its invaders.

Just as it was doing now.

KWA-DRRRRCK!

He couldn't see.

But he could picture it from the sound alone.

The fanatics wavering at this unexpected turn. The forest of countless spears and blades closing over them.

The undying will and desperate sense of duty carried by every one of those weapons.

"…Why?"

The Blood Lord barely managed to force out the word.

He wanted to ask Jin Taekyung. All of them.

What were they fighting so desperately for?

What could they hold so dear that they would give their lives to protect it?

Jin Taekyung answered that short question, laden with meaning, in two even shorter words.

"Fuck off."

"So you don't want to tell me."

"I'm sick of it. You're hardly the first idiot like this I've met. I've gone out of my way to explain it before, and none of you understood a damn thing."

"I see. So that's how it was."

The Blood Lord managed a weak nod. Jin Taekyung watched him, then asked abruptly, "What about you?"

"What?"

"What the hell were *you* doing all this for?"

The Blood Lord fell silent for a moment. His own silence startled him.

Was it the exhaustion weighing down his eyelids?

Or the sense of death drawing closer with every passing second?

"…I don't know."

He should have said that everything he'd done was for the Lord of Heaven. That he would do anything for his great master, and would swear loyalty even if he died here and became a ghost.

But the faithful servant's lips gave a different answer.

"I don't… know anymore. Anything."

With that faint murmur, the Blood Lord looked up at the sky.

Where was the heaven he had trusted so completely?

Would his master, somewhere impossibly far away, feel even a trace of grief when he heard that his most faithful servant had died?

Of course not.

A faint smile touched the Blood Lord's lips.

Yes.

He had tried to deny it, but he already knew the answer.

The Lord of Heaven hadn't wavered when the four Demon Lords and the Demon Empress died one after another. Nor when word came that countless followers had been wiped out.

Not for a single moment.

It was almost as if he'd wanted it to happen.

Then did you want this lowly servant to die, too?

The Blood Lord reached a trembling hand toward the sky.

Too far. He couldn't touch it.

Just like the distance between him and the Lord of Heaven. No matter how hard he'd tried, they had never grown any closer.

Ah.

The Blood Lord swallowed a groan.

He had believed in and revered the Lord of Heaven. But the light pouring down from that heaven had always shone on one person alone.

On the owner of those blazing eyes, who could no longer lift a finger yet still watched him die without looking away.

Jin Taekyung.

At that moment—

Shhk!

The fingers that had been reaching desperately through empty air curled like hooks and plunged downward.

The monster's final strike carried anger and hatred he no longer knew whom to direct at, and one last duty that now seemed futile.

Just as it was about to pierce Jin Taekyung between the eyes—

KRAK!

A hand caked in dried blood blocked it.

The bones in the monster's fingers shattered, joint by joint, and his flesh and blood burned.

Hiss.

A haze rose with the smell of scorching flesh.

Beyond it, the old master who had returned to his Disciple's side parted his lips.

"How dare you lay a hand on him?"

Through heat that penetrated even his dulled senses, the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, looked down at the monster trembling in pain.

And he wasn't alone.

The Bow Saint and the Slaughter Saint. Sword Saint Mae Jonghak and Cheongpung. Others, too, who had rushed over covered in blood.

They surrounded the monster like reapers, like iron towers.

They blotted out the sky that had been his whole world and became a broad, sturdy roof sheltering someone else from the rain.

That was why Jin Taekyung could laugh aloud.

He remembered the monster's joyful cry just moments ago.

"See them?"

He spoke emphatically to the monster, its blood-red eyes wide open.

"Those faces you're looking at? That's the paltry heaven I believed in."

"…!"

What could the monster say?

What more could he do?

He blinked helplessly, swallowed the blood spilling over his lips, and forced out a few last words.

"Rejoice… all you want. This will be the last time."

As his vision darkened to pitch-black, Jin Taekyung's voice reached him, faint and distant.

"I was planning to."

A bitter smile touched Jin Taekyung's lips. The monster breathed his last, and that breath dispersed into the air.

Ding.

A clear chime rang out like the bell of an ancient cathedral, announcing that everything was over.

It carried boundless joy—and even greater sorrow.

There's a saying: animals leave their hides behind when they die, and people leave their names.

But a monster that's neither animal nor human can leave behind a massive amount of EXP.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

The familiar clear chime rang nonstop in my ears.

If everyone could hear it instead of just me, I bet it would've carried for hundreds of ri.[3869]

That bastard sure knew how to make an exit.

The Blood Lord's end was miserable and shabby, but the System's payouts were lavish.

How many times had I leveled up in that brief instant?

Three? More?

I wasn't sure.

All I knew was that several Quests had been completed the moment the Blood Lord died, and I'd turned off notifications after my third Level Up.

Any other time, I'd have passed out from happiness.

No, I definitely would have. Leveling up had become a once-in-a-blue-moon event. Doing it several times in a row was nothing short of a miracle.

But none of it meant anything to me now.

The chimes that should have sounded like heaven were just irritating noise. Even having my crushed flesh and broken bones heal offered only a little comfort.

One small, final comfort: I could pat someone's trembling shoulder.

"Quit bawling. Your dick'll fall off."

Cheongpung didn't stop crying at my attempt to comfort him. He just spoke through his sobs.

He said he was sorry. And thanked me, too.

But my farewell to Cheongpung—surely our last—was brief.

Unlike him, I still had so many last faces left to see.

And once I'd seen them all, my own final moment would be waiting.

> **System** Time Limit: 5 minutes 35 seconds

I gazed calmly at the hourglass of the final rally, still hanging in the air.

Truthfully, I'd already guessed. Ever since I'd launched One Annihilation at the Blood Lord.

There was a limit to how much a Level Up could heal, and the injuries I'd suffered from One Annihilation's backlash went beyond it.

Now that what was called innate qi—or original true qi—had been damaged, my fate was like a boat that had crossed a river with no way back.

The System warned me, and I accepted it.

[3869] A Korean ri is about 393 m (0.244 mi).

That was all.

I'd taken the step I had to take, even knowing death might be waiting for me.

I had been prepared for this. If anything, I was grateful for the way things had turned out.

Without the healing from those Level Ups, without the extra time it had given me in the final rally, I wouldn't even have been able to say goodbye.

If that's what happened, then it was enough.

The Blood Lord was dead. Dark Heaven's army had crumbled. And I'd been given a few precious extra minutes.

Now I was smiling at faces I'd thought I'd never see again.

As if this were an ordinary, peaceful day, with no enemy to defeat and no one dear to me in need of protection.

Just like this moment.

Yeah.

I was ready to leave.

I had to be.

Chapter 1128

If I'd let myself think for just a little longer, I might have started crying without meaning to.

I knew better than anyone that I wasn't ready to leave yet.

But the time I'd thought was endless was inching toward its end even now, and I forced the corners of my mouth upward.

For my sake.

And for the sake of those who would remain and remember my final moments for a long time.

"Oh, you're here?"

Personally, I thought it was a very convincing performance.

A smiling face. A calm voice.

But the Fire Dragon Pavilion members, reunited with me at last, weren't foolish enough to miss what my condition and the heavy air around us meant.

"…Pavilion Master."

There was nothing more to say.

Sama Pyo stared at me blankly, then bit his lip. Song Ilseom quietly closed his eyes, and tears clouded Taishan's eyes, each as big as a calf's.

And Ju Hwaran—

Squish. Squish.

She staggered across a lake-like pool of blood and buried her trembling face against my shoulder.

That was all.

There were no more words, but it was enough for me.

They're all alive.

My ominous hunches were never wrong, but this time was the exception.

Seeing them safe, I felt my stiff smile soften.

Thank goodness. Really… thank goodness.

The smile on my lips wasn't an act anymore.

Gung Gibang and Cheongheoja appeared after the Fire Dragon Pavilion members.

Even the face of that wild-haired weirdo who gave me a headache every time I saw him made my heart swell with relief.

No—maybe it wasn't Great Sir himself I was so glad to see, but the person on his back.

"Don't worry. He suffered a serious internal injury, but the Seafaring King got the stagnant blood out in time. His life isn't in danger."

At the voice that suddenly reached my ears, I gave a small nod instead of answering.

Hyuk Mujin was unconscious and covered in blood from head to toe, but I could trust those words a hundred times over.

They came from none other than a man worthy of being called the greatest under heaven in this age.

“Swift Wind Sword Hyuk Mujin fought magnificently. He never gave an inch. He stood his ground with pride.”

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak added quietly, “Just like you.”

Hearing the sincerity in his voice, I parted my blood-crusted lips.

“Yes. I’m sure he did.”

I looked at Hyuk Mujin and smiled faintly.

“He’s my right arm, after all.”

Mae Jonghak had been watching me with a grave expression. Then he smiled along with me.

“So that’s how it is.”

“But he probably doesn’t know.”

“Why not?”

“I was always giving him a hard time. Told him he wasn’t nearly good enough to be my right arm.”

If there’d been even the slimmest chance I could recover, Mae Jonghak would have answered without hesitation.

Tell him yourself later.

He’ll be happy to hear it.

But like the Slaughter Saint and Bow Saint, who stood with their jaws clenched, he knew I didn’t have much time left.

“When he wakes, I’ll tell him exactly what you said. I won’t leave out a single word.”

“He’s so starved for praise that you can exaggerate all you like. For example…”

A conversation I’d had with Hyuk Mujin a long time ago came to mind, and I let out a quiet laugh.

“He has what it takes to become the Alliance Leader. Yeah. That’d make him faint with joy.”

“The next Alliance Leader, you say? I must reflect on this. My successor was right in front of me, and I failed to recognize him.”

“I’ll let it slide this time. You saved everyone, after all.”

“No. That’s not right.”

Tap.

Mae Jonghak placed a hand on my shoulder, his voice firm.

"It wasn't me who saved everyone. It was you. And they saved themselves, too."

"…!"

"Look. Listen. See who they're fighting for—and whose name they're shouting."

At that moment—

Fwoooosh.

Warm qi flowed from the fingers resting on my shoulder and seeped into me.

Like the sunset, it roused my fading consciousness. I saw the fanatics crumbling even now and heard our allies' shouts sweeping over them like a wave.

A roar that swallowed the fierce wind, the rain, and even the eight-character maxim.

"Fight back! For the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon, Jin Taekyung!"

Banners soared so high they seemed to pierce the sky, whipping wildly in the wind.

A forest of glittering steel covered the city and advanced, raising red flowers as it went.

Murim warriors, government troops, and commoners.

Three forces that mixed about as well as water and oil had come together as one, driving through the invaders.

All of them shouting my name.

Their desperate will and resolve drowned out even the fanatics' madness.

"…!"

I trembled before I knew it.

A lightning-like shiver ran up my spine, and Mae Jonghak's voice reached my ears.

"A month ago, when I went to persuade the Seafaring King, he told me that ships couldn't sail on a stormy night. The sails and oars would break, and without a single glimmer of light, you wouldn't even know which way was forward or back."

The age of war had come at last.

The sun of peace that had shone over the land for more than fifty years had disappeared. Night had fallen with the dark clouds of Dark Heaven, deep and black as pitch.

Deep enough to shake even the two giants of the dark path, who had once fought the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples led by the Heavenly Demon.

"The Green Forest Battle King said much the same thing. Both of them feared Dark Heaven's power, and spies planted in their ranks long ago had urged them to submit in order to survive."

But what I saw now was the exact opposite.

KRA-DRRRK!

Two streaks of red and blue Force flashed so fiercely I could make them out even from here.

At the heart of those vast energies, cutting down fanatics without mercy, were two Supreme Peak masters who ruled the mountains and rivers of the land.

“Yes, I managed to persuade them in the end. And it was easier than I expected.”

“How?”

“It was just like the Great Faction War. All they needed was someone they could believe in and move forward beside. A single ray of light.”

I didn’t know that distant past.

And yet I could guess what light had shone through the darkness of the Great Faction War.

That was probably why my eyes widened without my meaning to.

The brilliant light that had illuminated that age of war had vanished long ago.

“…No way.”

I looked at Mae Jonghak, smiling faintly, and asked as if groaning.

“Has the Martial God returned?”

His answer sent something hot surging up from deep in my chest.

“No. But you were here.”

“…!”

“One who goes ahead of everyone else to light the way. Someone who can bring everyone together because he isn’t bound by status or formality. That’s why you are the Blazing Flame Divine Dragon and Prince Shangshan—but before either of those, you’re a human being.”

His voice carried across the battlefield as though he were reciting a poem.

Countless feet trampled through the pools of blood left by the invaders, and dazzling spears and blades lit the darkness.

The darkness was fading. So was the flame inside me.

But the shouting didn’t stop.

Everyone in Xining was still calling my name at the top of their lungs.

As if mourning my death, just around the corner.

“Thank you. And I’m sorry. For coming too late. For failing to protect you.”

Mae Jonghak said much the same thing as Cheongpung had, crying just as he had. Then he had no choice but to turn away from me.

He was the Alliance Leader.

He had a duty to end this damn battle even a moment sooner and save as many lives as he could.

No.

Maybe he was also giving someone space.

Someone who stood a few steps behind me, frozen in body and spirit, watching it all in silence.

“What’s so amusing?”
His voice was so cold it seemed at odds with his title, the Fire King.
But I knew better than anyone that Jeok Cheongang’s anger was aimed at himself.
And I knew that smiling was the only thing I could do for him, when he must have been bleeding tears inside.
“What, I’m not even allowed to smile when I feel like it?”
“I can tell you’re forcing it.”
“…Is it that obvious?”
“Yeah. Look at the state you’re in.”
“I can’t see myself. Why don’t you bring me a mirror?”
“Do you need one? You’re covered in blood from head to toe, grinning like some evil spirit.”
“Like you’re in any position to talk.”
Jeok Cheongang and I fell silent.
Then, as if we’d planned it, we smiled at the same time.
We both knew it was the only way we could comfort each other, even a little.
Of course, we could see in each other’s eyes that neither smile was real.
“I can definitely tell you’re forcing that smile.”
“It isn’t easy.”
“No. It isn’t. Looking back, nothing ever was.”
I murmured weakly and looked at Jeok Cheongang.
The translucent hologram window stayed in the corner of my vision, no matter which way I turned my head.

> **System Time Limit:** 59 seconds

“Old Master.”
“Speak.”
“Do you think there really is an afterlife?”
“There must be. No—there definitely is.”
“How do you know?”
“Hong Dao said so. The great Abbot of Shaolin Temple said it, so you’d better believe him without arguing.”
“Come on. You always write him off as some damn monk.”
“This time, I intend to believe him.”
“Why?”
“…There has to be an afterlife for us to meet again.”

> **System Time Limit:** 30 seconds

“I don’t mind if it’s a long time before we meet. Come as late as you can.”
“It’ll take quite a while regardless. There are a lot of bastards I need to kill.”
“Now that you mention it, you’re right. That gives me an idea.”
“What is it?”
“Once you’ve killed those motherfuckers, I’ll be waiting in the afterlife to kill them again.”
“No.”
“What? Why not?”
“Just beat them until they’re about to die. Then we can kill them together one more time.”
“Wow. Are you a genius?”
“I suppose I was close to a natural disaster.”

> **System Time Limit:** 15 seconds

“By the way, Old Master.”
“Hmm?”
“I think I’m getting sleepy.”
“…Yeah. You must be exhausted.”
“I’m sorry, but could I ask you for a favor?”
“I’ll grant it. Anything.”
“I have family. They aren’t here, so I don’t think I’ll get to see them now.”

> **System Time Limit:** 10 seconds

“If you happen to meet them someday—though I know that probably won’t happen—could you tell them how I’m doing?”
“What must this old man do to reach the realm of immortals where you stayed?”
“I’m not sure. Ascend to immortality? I don’t really know.”
“Understood. I’ll find a way, whatever it takes. But you must grant this old man one favor in return.”
“Tell me.”

> **System Time Limit:** 5 seconds

I blinked weakly.

Through my blurring vision, I could see Jeok Cheongang crying like a child.
“Please… can’t you stay alive?”
As darkness closed in, I answered.
“I’m sorry, Master.”

> **System Time Limit:** 1 second

And then the entire world around me closed.

Chapter 1129

Looking back, I think I'd wondered about death since I was very young.

Not that I was particularly precocious.

I was just curious.

Why was the amusement park I'd been promised a trip to if I got a perfect score on my spelling test burning on TV?

Why was there a white bouquet on the desk of the classmate I'd played with just yesterday?

It didn't take long for me to learn the truth.

Death, destruction, grief, and anger.

Hunters and monsters. Gates left all over the world. A war that still hadn't ended.

That was simply the age we lived in.

An age of chaos, with truths too vast and terrible for anyone to hold back spilling out without end.

I soon understood why my parents had changed the TV channel with grim faces, and what the white bouquet on my friend's desk meant.

But my kindergarten teacher's description of my friend's absence as a "long journey" left me with even more questions.

I understood that she'd been trying to be kind. Still, one thought led to another.

Why do people die?

Where do they go when they die?

If they really do go on a journey, is there a world beyond death?

Even after many years, no one could answer those questions for me.

Of course they couldn't.

The departed don't speak.

So I wanted to find the answer from someone who had died, but wasn't dead anymore.

"Hey, Golgoli."

"A mere human like you dares call me by such a vulgar name? Can't you see this radiant crown?"

"Want me to make it so you can't see anything at all?"

"…Why did you call me? Get to the point."

Deep down, I'd believed Bones—or rather, the Skeleton King—could answer the question I'd carried for so long.

But faith has a way of being betrayed.

"The afterlife? I don't know why you're asking me."

"Does that mean—"

“That’s right. I don’t know a thing. I can’t remember my life before I died, so why would I know any more about what came after? I just woke up in the dark and found myself like this.”

It was ironic.

Even an undead being who had already crossed death’s threshold and been reborn didn’t know what lay beyond it.

In the end, I gave up looking for an answer.

Or rather, I put it off.

I’d find out someday.

Whether I wanted to or not, death would wait in the shadows for its moment, then swallow everything whole.

Just like now.

Ssshhh.

Everything blurred and drifted away.

The sky that had only just begun to clear. The faces looking down at me.

Their cries, and the shouts still rising from the battlefield.

The past I’d struggled through. The fleeting moments I’d let slip away.

All of it.

Ah.

With no voice left to escape my lips, I sank weakly.

Into pitch-black darkness.

Into the swamp of death, tugging hard at my soul.

And in a gap in time that felt like eternity, I heard a voice echo as if in a hallucination.

“Open your eyes.”

At that moment—

Whoosh!

A beam of light appeared from nowhere, somehow, tearing through the darkness and illuminating the world.

A new world, where everything had changed.

I blinked blankly.

Then I took in the sight before me and wondered:

Where am I?

The gray-white space stretched on without end. Even “vast” felt too small a word for it.

The horizon far in the distance was hazy. When I looked up, I saw a ceiling that seemed higher and more distant than the sky.

It felt as though I'd been shut inside a gigantic box.

Strangely, though, I wasn't afraid.

For all its emptiness, the infinite space inspired an awe I couldn't explain just by looking at it.

Yes.

The answer to the question I'd carried for so long was here.

Though it looked nothing like I'd imagined.

"Hmm. I suppose so."

"…!"

A voice came from behind me without any hint of someone's presence. I instinctively twisted away and retreated, fixing my gaze on the uninvited guest standing only a few steps away.

"…You're—"

I had no time to marvel at the fact that I could speak.

The unexpected visitor—an old man—was far more shocking.

He, on the other hand, sounded perfectly calm.

"Do you know who I am?"

I nodded and tried to answer evenly.

"The Grim Reaper?"

"…"

"Uh, no?"

After a brief silence, the old man shook his head.

"Think whatever you like. It isn't important."

"It's pretty important to me."

"Why? Worried you'll be dragged to hell?"

"Honestly, yes."

"You must have sinned a lot."

"…Who knows?"

I gave the old man, whoever he was, a bitter smile.

I'd sometimes wondered whether every enemy I'd defeated had really deserved to die like that.

Whether the mountain of corpses and river of blood I'd made with my own hands could be weighed against all the lives saved because of me.

Maybe I deserve to go to hell more than anyone.

That was when he spoke.

"You're worrying over nothing. It's not so easy to end up in hell."

The old man's sunken gaze settled on me.

As if he could see right through my thoughts.

"And the people you miss won't be there, either."

"…!"

"Isn't that what worries you most? That you might die and still never see them again?"

For a moment, I couldn't speak. I stared at him, frozen like a statue, then barely managed to force out the words.

"Wait. Is this, by any chance—"

"Ah, forgive me. I didn't mean to let that slip."

His answer all but confirmed my guess.

As I struggled to find the words, the old man shrugged.

"Well, there it is."

"I knew something was off. So it really was true."

"It happens more often than you'd think. When the thing you thought couldn't happen does. It's easier if you think of it as just one of those cases."

There was nothing simple or comforting about that. Yet, for some reason, I found it surprisingly easy to accept.

Even who owned that voice, the one that had sounded like a hallucination just before I opened my eyes in this strange place.

"You're quick on the uptake. Good."

I took another look at the old man, who now read my thoughts as naturally as breathing.

A robe without a speck of dust on it. A beard long enough to reach the floor.

And something about him that felt oddly familiar.

"Have we… met before?"

The old man seemed to ponder the question for a while before answering.

"We may have. Or we may not."

"Excuse me?"

"That's the best answer I can give. I have my own circumstances to consider. I've already gone quite far out of my way to help you."

"You helped me? How?"

"Find the answer to that question yourself. You don't have as much time as you think, so… let's get started."

I wanted to ask what on earth he was talking about, and what he meant by *begin*.

But the instant his figure blurred, every tangled thought in my head vanished.

Pop.

I hadn't seen him move. I hadn't even sensed it.

He was so fast he left no afterimage.

By the time I turned, he had crossed the few steps between us and taken position behind me. His fist blotted out my vision.

Thud!

My vision swam, and strength left my legs.

I'd never seen an attack so fast and precise.

I had no reason to fight anymore. Even so, I forced my buckling legs to hold and reached out on instinct.

Whoosh—BOOM!

Indigo flames engulfed the gray-white space.

Before I could even think about why I had internal energy here, the old man's calm voice rang out from beyond the scorching heat.

"The Flame Divine Palm. An excellent martial art."

"…How do you know that?"

"Didn't I tell you? Keep it simple and accept it."

Whoosh.

The flames parted as he answered.

Without even forming Palm Force, the old man waved a hand and blew away the heat of the Flame Divine Palm as if snuffing out a candle. Then he signaled to me with his eyes.

"Go on. Struggle all you like. Try the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist—or better yet, the Blazing Flame Divine Spear."

"…!"

"Ah, but not One Annihilation. For your sake, not mine."

Was this what it felt like to be haunted by a ghost?

I could only stare at the ghost—or rather, the old man—in a daze, unable to speak.

Of course, he didn't even allow me that moment.

Slash!

When had he moved? How?

He'd been standing amid the dying flames, but now he was in my blind spot. Invisible qi carried on the edge of his hand swept smoothly across my chest.

So sharp that a beat later, the flesh it sliced through—like tofu—let out a scream.

Splurt!

Blood sprayed into the air. At the same time, a distant pain I'd thought I'd never feel again came surging back.

So did the fear I'd briefly forgotten.

At this rate… I'll die.

It was bizarre.

I’d already died once, yet here I was thinking about dying again.

But I had no time to question it.

Against a power that seemed capable of erasing not just my body but my soul, I had to struggle with everything I had.

“Good. That’s right. Looks like you’re finally starting to understand the situation.”

The old man nodded, seeing straight through my thoughts. A curse escaped before I could stop it.

“You crazy old bastard.”

“High praise. Thank you.”

“What… the hell are you?”

“Who knows? I might be your grandfather.”

The old man smiled faintly for the first time. While I stood speechless at the unexpected family insult, he reached toward me.

No—he held something out.

A spear that had suddenly appeared in midair.

“Take it. Even if you’re going to die, you should at least get to fight back properly once, shouldn’t you?”

I gritted my teeth.

Then I caught the shaft as the spear flew slowly toward me and spat out the words.

“You’re dead.”

The old man replied, “May you be reborn in paradise.”

At that moment—

Shhhk!

A dazzling flash of light streaked across the vast gray-white space.

Chapter 1130

Light doesn't exist only to illuminate.

Sometimes it erases everything and lets you forget.

Just like the beam flying toward Jin Taekyung now, filling his vision with white.

Whooooooosh!

As the flash swelled, Jin Taekyung's gaze sank low.

He cleared every stray thought and question from his mind.

No—he had no choice.

The beam had split into dozens, and each one writhed as if alive, aiming for a vital point on his body.

It's no feint.

Every one of those solid beams held terrifying destructive power unlike anything he'd ever experienced.

But Jin Taekyung chose to advance, not retreat.

Fwoosh—BOOM!

Flames streamed from the foot he drove forward. Keeping low, he shot through the rain of light, narrowly slipping past each beam. The old man watched him and nodded.

"The Flamefire Path. You certainly know how to fight."

Jin Taekyung answered the praise in his own way.

Ssshh.

As the distance between them vanished, his spear surged toward the old man. Afterimages engulfed it, rippling like a wave.

Like the tail of a colossal dragon.

Whoooosh!

Indigo flames rose along the spearhead. As with the old man's move moments earlier, they split into dozens in an instant and surged forward, blanketing the space.

KWA-BOOM!

If a hell of boiling sulfurous fire existed, would it look like this?

Yet even before that lava-like heat, the old man's calm eyes did not waver.

Nor did his hands as he brought them together to meet the spearhead amid that life-or-death crisis.

Crack!

For an instant, Jin Taekyung's eyes flew wide.

The trembling spearhead was reflected in Jin Taekyung's eyes between the old man's palms, pressed together as if in prayer.

"…How?"

The question escaped before he knew it.

The old man, who had blown away every flame coming at him simply by bringing his palms together, looked puzzled.

"Hm? I just grabbed it."

"…!"

"Anyway, try something hotter this time. This is making me pleasantly drowsy. Not bad."

Jin Taekyung felt his vision swim.

The old man was already a madman for stopping his full-power strike with Empty-Hand Seizes the Blade. And now he was treating several jiazi[3870] of Scorching Yang Qi—hot enough to melt steel—as if it were hot spring water.

What kind of old man is this?

Even the Blood Lord, the strongest opponent he'd faced until now, hadn't been this powerful.

Not even close.

The Blood Lord had used blood to gain healing that bordered on Regeneration and a seemingly endless supply of internal energy. But even that terrifying power had its limits.

The old man was different. His very nature, his level, was different from the Blood Lord's.

Jin Taekyung sensed no particular killing intent in eyes as still as a secluded lake. Yet merely facing the old man made his whole body freeze.

It was like standing before an enormous wall he could never climb, no matter how hard he struggled.

And the old man saw straight into that passing thought.

"Your head's full of stray thoughts. You must still have some life left in you. In that case…"

At that moment—

CRASH!

The spearhead in the old man's grasp shattered. His palm glided forward and touched Jin Taekyung's chest.

BOOM!

An explosion rang out from deep within his body.

Jin Taekyung dropped to one knee as pain bleached his vision white. Even through the ringing in his ears, the old man's whisper came through with startling clarity.

"I'll clear those stray thoughts away for you again."

[3870] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

"…!"

Jin Taekyung had no time to answer, let alone recover from the pain.

More precisely, the old man didn't give him any.

Whoosh!

A massive force descended toward the crown of his head with a heavy rush of air.

The energy wave was so terrifying it made him forget even the pain. Jin Taekyung rolled to the side without time to think.

KWA-BOOM!

A roar like the sky splitting apart shook the space, followed by a shock wave that swept in every direction.

Jin Taekyung felt himself thrown far away, as if weightless. Behind him, the old man appeared, having crossed more than ten jang[3871] in an instant.

"Good judgment. If you hadn't used Narye tagon,[3872] it would've ended there."

Normally, Jin Taekyung would have told an enemy to shut the hell up, no matter who it was.

Not this time.

Every part of him knew that against this old man, even a single deep breath—or the smallest stray thought—was a luxury he couldn't afford.

"You only just figured out something that simple?"

…and that as long as this mysterious old man could read his mind, he would never escape this damned situation.

"Oh, that's quite an insight. So what will you do now?"

Meeting the old man's interested gaze, Jin Taekyung used what remained of his spear as a cane and pushed himself upright.

Slowly. Carefully.

By the time he stood on both feet, he had found his answer.

Ssshh.

His eyes closed.

The thought that he was doing something insane, and the fear of what might happen, lasted only a moment. His trembling eyelids grew still, shutting out everything his eyes had shown him.

By giving up that one thing, Jin Taekyung gained something new.

The thread of enlightenment he hadn't managed to follow to its end during the fierce battle against Dark Heaven.

And the only way through the situation he faced now.

At the sight of him, the old man smiled faintly once more.

[3871] A jang is a traditional Korean length of ten ja, about 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

[3872] Narye tagon is a martial-arts expression for an evasive roll that likens the fighter to a lazy donkey rolling on the ground.

“Yes. That’s how it should be.”

At that moment—

Pop.

As if on cue, the young man and the old man shot toward each other.

Fwoosh—BOOM!

Jin Taekyung thrust out the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist as if entranced.

Heat that seemed capable of melting even a thousand-year-old boulder swept through the gray-white space. But he already knew.

He could feel it.

The old man was no longer there.

He was moving faster than sound, slipping into Jin Taekyung’s blind spot.

BOOM!

Jin Taekyung twisted like lightning. A powerful palm strike slammed through the air where his head had been a moment earlier.

“Much better.”

In the darkness behind his closed eyes, Jin Taekyung swallowed a breath as he barely evaded the attacks closing in from every direction.

Was it his imagination?

The old man’s voice, once clearer than anything else, now sounded fainter and farther away than an echo.

“The fact that you can still hear me means you’re not there yet.”

He was right. Maybe.

It was nothing new. It had always been this way.

He hadn’t been strong enough to protect everyone. The guilt and anxiety had brought nightmares night after night.

He had wavered like a candle in the wind, then guttered out.

“But that is greed. Humans cannot become perfect.”

Jin Taekyung knew that, too.

But even if what he wanted went beyond desire into greed, he didn’t care.

He only wanted to save someone, and to live himself.

To live alongside the people he cherished in a more peaceful world.

“Everyone dreams of that. Reality is cruel, though.”

Despite his calm voice, the old man pressed him without pause.

A foot that snapped like a whip, a hand slicing diagonally downward, a palm extending smoothly—each was a sword or spear.

There was no fierce killing intent in any of those moves, yet each brimmed with enough qi to seemingly obliterate not just his body, but his soul.

“Who knows? Perhaps entering perfect rest just like this would be a good thing for you.”

At those words, Jin Taekyung’s retreating steps stopped as though nailed to the ground.

KWA-BOOM!

Two fists collided in midair.

The old man was so wrinkled that Jin Taekyung couldn’t begin to guess his age, and his fist held a force almost impossible to withstand. Jin Taekyung braced himself, though his feet slowly slid back.

“What do you mean by that?”

The question came through clenched teeth. The old man answered calmly.

“What do you think I mean?”

“…You can’t mean—”

“Good. You seem to know already. There’s no time left, so let’s settle this now.”

Just as Jin Taekyung was about to ask what he meant, the old man’s fist gathered more force and shoved him away.

KWA-BOOM!

Jin Taekyung shot backward like a cannonball.

He barely regained his balance in midair. The moment he landed, he felt the space around him hum.

Hmmm.

He couldn’t see it. But he could picture it.

Far away, a formless sword pointed straight at him. The old man held it in his hands—a sword made not of metal, but entirely of qi.

“Try to dodge it. If you can’t… then this is as far as you go.”

Jin Taekyung could no longer ask what that meant.

He couldn’t even bring himself to open his eyes. If he lost his tenuous hold on this new sensation for even an instant, or let the slightest stray thought intrude, he felt certain his body would be cut to pieces.

And that judgment was right.

Gooooong.

The gray-white space trembled as the old man slowly raised both hands.

At the same time, a faint beam of light flowed into some corner of Jin Taekyung’s pitch-black vision.

What is this?

A sensation he had never felt before.

Or rather, it had come to him only very rarely after he combined three forms of internal energy, lingering briefly before fading.

Reason had no place in it. It belonged to instinct.

It was a realm where the body moved before the mind gave an order—no, somewhere beyond even that.

It was taking hold of Jin Taekyung's mind, touching on the sixth sense.

At last, he stared straight at the invisible sword slashing down from the old man's fingertips.

Sssshing!

At the instant a sound like the whole world splitting apart rang out—

Whoooosh.

Jin Taekyung saw it.

A single beam of light, brightening his vision as dark as the deep night.

And, as if entranced, he stepped forward.

Shhk!

Chapter 1131

In time brought to a standstill, amid a silence that seemed to last forever, I slowly opened my eyes.

It was a strange feeling.

My mind was hazy, as though lost in thick fog, yet I could see more clearly than ever. Clearly enough to wonder if all of this was a dream.

But the low voice that reached my ears a moment later reminded me that this was no illusion.

“Did you see it?”

I looked up at the old man, dazed.

Then, recalling the formless qi that had flown across the space moments ago, cleaving it in two and missing me by no more than a thread, I parted my lips.

“Yes. I saw it.”

Everything felt natural. The respect that had crept into my voice, and the way the old man accepted it as if it were only right.

“What did you see?”

“A ray of light. A line.”

The old man stroked his snow-white beard, which hung down to his knees.

“How could that be? It must have been formless.”

“It had a form. For that moment, at least.”

“Even with your eyes closed?”

“I didn’t see it with my eyes.”

“You saw it, but didn’t see it. Then what was it?”

“That…”

I faltered.

Not because I didn’t know the answer, but because the thought that had flashed through my mind sounded absurd even to me.

My silence was as good as an answer, though. The old man’s unfathomable gaze was already looking into my heart.

“People often have the truth right before their eyes and still pass it by because they cannot believe it. What a pity.”

Step.

One step was all it took for the old man to close the distance between us. He whispered:

“You saw what cannot be seen, and dodged what could not be dodged. Why can’t you believe you did it?”

“…!”

"Sit cross-legged."

Still hazy as though in a dream, I sat as he instructed, almost without knowing what I was doing.

Then I heard his voice again—not in my ears, but inside my head.

—Clear your mind like a stream. Hold your focus and let yourself follow the flow.

A thought came to me. I'd heard something like this before, somewhere.

But it was gone in an instant as my awareness sank deeper.

Fwoooosh.

Light and darkness flickered without end before my eyes, leaving me disoriented.

Amid that overwhelming confusion, I forgot everything.

Where I was. Who I was.

Yet the voice coming from somewhere remained astonishingly clear.

—Remember what you saw. How it felt in that moment.

I took a slow, deep breath.

Then I spoke the name of the thing with no shape, color, or scent in my mind.

Qi.

Everywhere and nowhere.

The source and seed of all things in the world.

Yes.

For a brief moment, I had seen it clearly—through a new realm beyond the senses.

And the owner of the voice echoing deep within my soul was someone who had already set foot in that realm.

—I'll ask again. What did you see it with?

Right. I still hadn't answered the old man's question.

This time, though, I could answer without hesitation. That other eye hidden within me—the one even I hadn't believed in—

My heart. No…

The Mind's Eye.

The moment those two words came to me and were branded into my mind—

—Good judgment, as always.

Flash!

At the sound of the old man's low voice, the light and darkness that had kept flickering before my eyes scattered.

Or rather, everything around me did.

"Ah."

I let out the breath I'd been holding and looked around.

Crack. Crack.

Why was this happening? How was it possible?

The vast, endless gray-white space was shaking.

Cracks spread in every direction like a pane of glass about to shatter, and the figure of the man standing beyond it twisted along with the shifting space.

“Don’t be alarmed. The time we were granted is simply coming to an end.”

His voice was calm, at odds with the impossible sight before me. I stared at him as though entranced.

Then, recalling a fragment of a memory I’d long forgotten, I finally spoke.

“I’ve met you before. I’m sure of it.”

The old man smiled faintly.

“Is that what you think?”

Neither a yes nor a no.

But now I was certain. The gray-white space and the old man might look different from how they had then, but neither had changed at the heart of it.

I knew whose voice had come to me now and then like an auditory hallucination ever since my Bone Transformation.

“You’re…”

I could barely force the word out as I looked at the old man smiling silently before me.

No.

The Helper.

The one who had first taught me to circulate my qi when I’d only just stepped into the unknown world of Murim.

The mysterious being I’d taken for part of the tutorial System, and forgotten for so long because of it.

“…Who on earth are you?”

Was this what it felt like to have lightning strike the top of your head?

Faced at last with a truth this immense, I trembled as the shock washed over me like a tidal wave.

At the same time, I knew it instinctively. The old man would never answer, and even this brief meeting was drawing to a close.

“No need to answer. I already know.”

Grgrgrk.

The space contorted. I could no longer make out the old man’s face, but I shouted toward him.

“Then what—what happens now?”

“Who knows? I don’t know what lies ahead, either. For now, we have no choice but to return to our respective places.”

“What does that—”

“Jin Taekyung.”

His voice was low. Cutting me off, he spoke.

“Do your best. Only then can you save everyone—and yourself.”

“…!”

“Now it’s time to go. To the place where you belong.”

My eyes widened as I understood what he meant.

Whoooosh.

The world in my sight rushed past as I was drawn away. Something glimmering touched my hand, and the old man’s final words rang through my head like a voice I was only imagining.

—Take it. This is the last gift this old man can give you.

I instinctively clenched my hand around it.

As my consciousness faded, I heard a sound from somewhere. A clear bell chime I’d been certain I would never hear again.

Ding.

A brilliant light came rushing from far away and filled my vision.

Left alone, the old man gazed in silence at the empty place for a long while.

To the person who had just vanished, it must have looked as though the entire gray-white space was disappearing. But the old man knew better.

This space would last forever. Jin Taekyung had only been a guest passing through.

And the old man would once again have to wait, with no telling when that wait might end.

“When will I be able to finish this?”

He murmured to himself. After so long alone, talking to himself had become a habit.

“No. Will it ever end at all?”

A bitter smile touched his wrinkled lips as he looked around.

Gray-white space stretched endlessly in every direction. Cold and pale, it was his only home—and a vast prison with neither bars nor an exit.

The emptiness that thought brought lasted only a moment. His gaze soon grew calm again.

After all, no one had forced him to become a prisoner here. He had chosen it himself.

“Yes. So that’s enough.”

He murmured the words as though renewing a promise to himself, then started walking.

Then, suddenly, he stopped and turned to look back along the way he’d come.

Or, more precisely, at the place where the guest who had visited after so long had stayed.

"Jin Taekyung."

The name left his lips, and he wondered if Taekyung could do it. If the choice he had made had truly been the right one.

And if he'd made the wrong choice, how terrible and cruel would the future ahead be?

But all those worries were meaningless.

The old man had already made his choice, and thanks to his help, Jin Taekyung had been given another chance.

"I suppose I'll have to put my faith in you."

The words would never reach Taekyung. The old man began walking again, slowly crossing the endless gray-white space as he always had.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was crying.

He held his Disciple's lifeless body and sobbed quietly. Nothing around him mattered anymore—not the shouts and clash of steel that still rang out, nor the people watching him.

The Master who had lost his only Disciple did not hold back his tears.

He couldn't.

Two years.

Only two years out of a life that had lasted more than a hundred. Yet his time with Jin Taekyung had shone brighter than any other.

Taekyung had been the only light to find him when he was at his darkest.

And now Jin Taekyung—his Disciple—was dead.

Despite his Master's plea for him to live, he had gone somewhere far away.

I'm sorry, Master.

That final voice wouldn't leave his ears.

The corners of Taekyung's mouth, raised with effort into a smile for his grieving Master. His half-closed, empty eyes. Even now, the sight seared into Jeok Cheongang's heart like a brand.

Grief overwhelmed him until he could make sense of nothing. Tears kept filling his eyes, hiding what he needed to see.

Plip.

A tear rolled down the Master's cheek and fell onto the back of his dead Disciple's hand.

Sss.

The surface of the blood rippled with a sudden tremor, and the finger submerged in it moved.

Chapter 1132

No one there had dared to imagine it.

That the body of someone already dead would move.

Perhaps that was why even the few who saw his fingers twitch failed to realize what it meant.

They put it down to the grieving Master's touch as he held his Disciple's body and sobbed, the lingering vibrations of the battlefield—or simply their imagination.

An illusion born of the desperate wish that the young hero who had met such a noble end might come back to life, even now.

The Master, sunk in grief, thought no differently.

Thump.

At first, he thought he'd imagined the sound.

But when a vibration traveled through the Disciple he held so tightly, Jeok Cheongang could only blink in a daze.

How?

It couldn't be. It was impossible.

Yet contrary to what Jeok Cheongang's instincts told him, the vibration, once begun, did not stop.

It grew louder and clearer.

Like a war drum beating out the order to charge.

Thump. Thump-thump.

"…!"

In an instant, Jeok Cheongang hurriedly pressed his ear to his Disciple's chest. His eyes flew wide.

There was no mistaking it. He wasn't hearing things.

The heart that had stopped was beating again. An extinguished ember had caught fire once more.

And just as Jeok Cheongang shuddered at the impossible truth—

Fwoosh!

A scorching wind surged up around one person's body.

No—

A tremendous wave of qi, powerful enough to envelop a radius of a dozen or so *jang*[3873].

Rrrrmmm.

The space trembled in tiny shivers, like a living creature.

Everyone still nearby stared, eyes wide.

[3873] *Jang* is a traditional Korean unit of length. One *jang* is about 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

They watched dark blue heat waver like a mirage around the young man slowly rising at its center.

“Ah, ah…!”

An exclamation thick with emotion escaped Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

Most people were simply overwhelmed by the mysterious sight. But he knew all too well what it meant.

So did the two other giants who had remained to witness it, unlike Sword Saint Mae Jonghak, who had gone to bring the long battle to an end.

“…Am I seeing this right?”

The Slaughter Saint sounded unable to believe it. The Bow Saint answered in a voice that trembled, unlike her usual one.

“I think so. No, I’m sure of it.”

Watching the young man rise out of his Master’s arms, she murmured as if to herself.

“Bone Transformation.”

At that moment—

Ssshh!

The heat that had surged like waves and the dark blue streaks of light gathered with sudden force.

Toward the body, still warm.

To rekindle the faint ember within.

People had feared fire since ancient times.

A campfire burning in the mountains at night could give them strength, but greater heat could bring disaster.

So they saw fire as a force of destruction, overlooking the power to purify hidden behind it.

And now, the heat surrounding one person’s body was unquestionably a purifying flame.

Flicker.

Though trapped in a state of consciousness where he couldn’t tell dream from reality, Jin Taekyung could feel it clearly.

The heat surging from deep within him.

The agony of his whole body burning, and at the same time, the cool relief of his wounds being washed clean.

Kwoooosh!

A wave of fire overflowed in every direction. The terrible heat seemed ready to melt even his already-healed body in an instant.

Yet for some reason, Jin Taekyung felt not a trace of fear.

Of course he didn't.

He understood it instinctively.

That immense heat wasn't only sweeping through his body, melting every limb and bone. It was also peeling back a layer to reveal the unknown power hidden within him.

But that wasn't the only reason Jin Taekyung could calmly accept his transformation.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

Beyond his hazy sight and senses, chimes rang out one after another.

They were clearer than ever—the chimes he'd thought he would never hear again. Words swept past his eyes like the wind, tickling his retinas.

New enlightenment and achievements tied to it. Increases in Qi Sense and martial arts…

Unable to bear the weight of the words pouring down without end, Jin Taekyung closed his eyes.

He focused entirely on the landscape of his mind and sank deep beneath the surface.

The next moment, he found himself standing somewhere new.

Where is this?

He had seen it only once, yet it was familiar.

How could he forget?

Far below lay endless land and sea. Clouds filled the sky as far as he could see. It was a beautiful sight.

The peak. It's the same peak as before.

When he had brought together the Heavenly Power Demon's demonic qi, the Thunderbolt Saber King's lightning qi, and his own Scorching Yang Qi, Jin Taekyung had finally conquered this lofty peak.

He had stepped into a new realm: the Summit of Martial Achievement.

But that was all.

He had claimed the peak that touched the clouds, but no matter how far he reached, he couldn't touch the sky beyond them.

That realm hadn't been open to him then.

He hadn't yet earned the right—the enlightenment—to glimpse it, even for a moment.

Yes. That was how it *had* been.

Until today, when the old man had given him another insight.

Climbing higher was never the only answer.

He had simply taken that answer for granted.

But now he knew.

Raising the peak beneath his feet wasn't the only way to glimpse the sky beyond these thick clouds.

There's more than one answer.

Why hadn't he realized it?

He had always gone beyond anything he'd imagined possible. So why had he set limits on his thinking?

Jin Taekyung suddenly remembered a conversation he'd forgotten.

When he was a novice martial artist, still stuck at Second Rate, he had asked Jin Wikyung how on earth he could reach the First Rate realm. His brother had answered with a single word: *faith.*

"What does that… mean?"

"Exactly what it sounds like. Believe in yourself."

"What does believing have to do with advancing realms?"

"Martial arts begin with belief."

Only then had he understood.

Now he understood.

The person who had believed in Jin Taekyung least wasn't anyone else. It was Jin Taekyung himself.

Even after he'd far surpassed Jin Wikyung's martial prowess, even after he'd earned the right—he had always been that way.

But not anymore.

He decided to try believing, just a little.

In the old man's words: Don't set limits for yourself.

In the potential he had yet to discover.

If I want to see it, I can.

At the very top of the peak, Jin Taekyung lifted his head as if spellbound.

He looked at the clouds streaming across his path, blocking the view in his mind.

Not with his eyes, but with his heart.

With the Mind's Eye.

And the next moment—

Fwoosh!

The clouds scattered as if by magic. Light flooded his vision, turning it white, and pain shot through him as though his retinas were burning.

"…!"

Was this what it felt like to be thrown into a vast pit of fire?

Or would dozens, hundreds of bolts of lightning striking down at once hurt like this?

But Jin Taekyung held on to the thread of his fading consciousness with all his might.

Fighting the pain that threatened to turn his mind to mush, he endured the unprecedented heat pouring down with the light.

Even that was enough to make his body and every memory in his head feel as though they were burning away.

Who he was.

Where he was.

Yet he did not forget the one thing that mattered: why he was enduring this terrible pain.

I have to go back. No matter what.

He had left something precious behind.

He had failed to protect what he needed to protect, and there was still something he had to do.

That alone was reason enough to endure.

If he could return, he could bear this agony, each second stretching into ten years.

Even the terrible heat that had seeped deep into his body and flowed through it like lava.

But widening his own limits did not mean every boundary had disappeared.

Kiiiiing.

This was a limit he could not overcome by will. A boundary he truly lacked the qualifications to cross.

And the moment Jin Taekyung realized it—

Ssshhh.

Thick clouds once again hid the light. The immense heat still flowing inside him spread through his body, passing through hundreds of acupoints rather than his Lower or Middle Dantian.

There it was absorbed, melting into him as though it had been part of his body from the start.

As though it were replenishing the natural strength of his body, damaged beyond recovery, and giving him still greater vitality and power.

Ah.

In that instant, Jin Taekyung understood.

His endurance had not been in vain.

The old man’s words—that it was time for each of them to return to their own places—could finally come true.

And his hunch was right.

Ding.

A clear chime rang out beyond the depths of his consciousness, and Jin Taekyung —

No.

I opened my eyes.

This time, I didn’t need anyone’s help.

As the dark blue radiance that had blazed for half a day slowly faded, a suffocating silence fell over everything.

The allies who had finally won this horrific bloodbath, and the fanatics who had survived by sheer luck and been captured—

No one dared speak.

It was as if even the dead were watching the figure slowly descend through the fading heat.

But unlike those frozen in place, forgetting even how to breathe, the old Master reached out with a trembling hand to catch his Disciple.

His body was warm now, like a campfire.

A thought struck Jeok Cheongang.

What if none of this were real?

If it were a spring dream[3874] unfolding in the mind of an old man who had already gone mad, what would he do?

He couldn’t bring himself to speak.

If this truly was a dream, he would rather never wake.

But someone knew what Jeok Cheongang did not.

That all of this was undeniably real.

“I kept my promise.”

Half-raised eyelids. A languid voice.

The Disciple smiled at the Master staring at him in a daze, then added:

“Master.”

[3874] A “spring dream” (*chunmong*) is a Korean expression for a fleeting or illusory experience.

Chapter 1133

The moment a small but unmistakable voice slipped between someone's lips, the countless people surrounding him all widened their eyes at once, as if they'd agreed to do it together.

What should they call this?

Survival?

Or resurrection?

No one knew the answer.

All they knew was that something hot surged up from deep within their chests.

"…!"

"…!"

A choked roar rose beyond the Inner City, powerful enough to shake heaven and earth.

The rain that had poured down without end had long since stopped, but their cries didn't let up.

Some wept. Some laughed. Others raised their weapons high and roared as if the battle still raged.

Exhausted as they were, they rejoiced with all their hearts.

The brutal bloodbath that had seemed as if it would never end was over.

And yet, alongside their joy, they felt a grief too deep for words.

They saw the empty places left by comrades who had stood shoulder to shoulder and fought back to back with them only several *shichen*[3875] ago.

Finally, they shuddered at the sight before their eyes: a young hero awakening amid a blue-black radiance, a miracle beyond belief.

His Master watched his Disciple with an expression of disbelief, then parted his trembling lips and spoke.

"Yeah. I believed in you."

Despite his answer, his eyes were soaked with tears.

At the sight of Jeok Cheongang, Jin Taekyung said nothing. He only managed a faint smile.

Whether his Master had believed in him or not—what did it matter?

What mattered was the feeling in his Master's tears, and that he had kept his promise.

I'm back. Really.

Perhaps it was because his mind was exhausted beyond its limits.

[3875] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

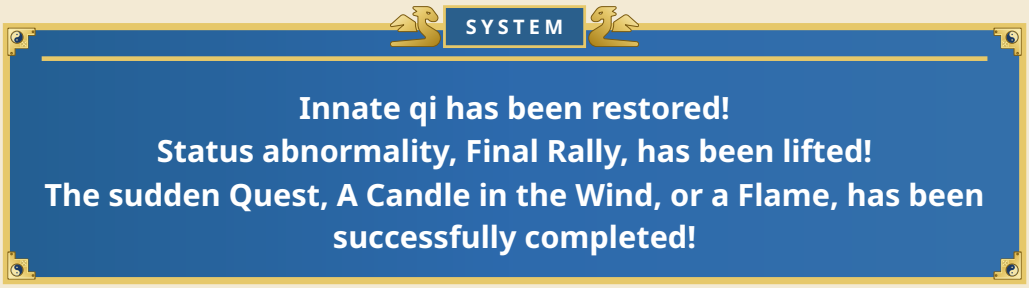
His consciousness was hazy, as if he'd sunk deep into sleep, but Jin Taekyung knew that everything around him was real.

The sky slowly clearing.

The familiar faces surrounding him now, laughing and crying, though he'd thought he would never see them again.

And—

Among the countless holographic windows floating in the air, the words that stood out largest and clearest.



Would he become a candle, its flame dying helplessly away?

Or a blaze that devoured his enemies?

At that crossroads, Jin Taekyung had chosen the latter, and the dying ember inside him had finally been reignited.

The ember called innate qi.

And the second Bone Transformation that followed was nothing short of a miracle—one no one present could have expected.

Not even the peerless giant known as the Sword Saint.

"You make a lot of noise in your sleep. More than I ever imagined."

At Mae Jonghak's joking remark as he came over, Jin Taekyung let out a quiet snort of laughter.

"I almost woke up halfway through. It was so noisy around me."

"Is it still?"

"Yes."

Jin Taekyung glanced at his allies, who were still cheering, and added:

"But… it sounds good."

It sounds good.

At Jin Taekyung's brief comment, Mae Jonghak watched him in silence, then gave a small nod.

"Yes. I think so too."

No one needed to ask about the battle's outcome, or explain it.

The proof was all around them: countless allies surrounding them, and a handful of fanatics on their knees, bound from head to toe.

The battle is over.

At those few words, something hot surged up from one corner of Jin Taekyung's chest.

Perhaps this was only a victory for today.

Today's victory might be erased by a defeat tomorrow, whenever that day came.

But… for now, this was enough.

Enough that this horrific hellscape had come to an end.

Enough that they had defeated the enormous Dark Heaven army that had stood in their way like a mountain, along with the powerful enemies who led it.

The Blood Lord. And the Grand Sorceress.

Jin Taekyung lifted his head and looked northeast.

He didn't know how many more enemies lurked beyond the vast desert outside Qinghai.

But the deaths of the Blood Lord and the Grand Sorceress on this battlefield were undoubtedly a major gain for the allies.

He couldn't be certain, but as far as he could tell, those two had been the Lord of Heaven's last hunting dogs.

But… what is this feeling?

A sudden sense of déjà vu made Jin Taekyung's eyelids flutter.

Why?

He felt as if he'd forgotten something.

Something very important—something he couldn't afford to overlook.

But it didn't take him long to realize what that feeling was.

Whoooosh!

The next moment, Jin Taekyung's eyes flew wide as he saw a dozen or so shadows shoot up into the distant sky.

Those are…!

They were none other than strange birds.

They flew across the sky with their wings spread wide, white bone joints exposed and blood-red eyes flashing.

Like messengers rushing to deliver urgent news to someone.

"No!"

The shout burst from him on instinct.

But before he could do anything, the birds, already far away, shot west at a speed far beyond anything they'd managed while alive.

They left one name flashing through Jin Taekyung's mind like a bolt of lightning.

"…Ma Sanbao?"

He'd forgotten about him for a moment.

No—that wasn't quite right. He hadn't had even a moment to think about him.

The powerful corpse sorcerer who carried on the Maoshan Sect's legacy had been hidden from sight by the shadows of the two monsters, the Blood Lord and the Grand Sorceress.

At the same time, the Blood Lord's final words before he met his end rang through Jin Taekyung's mind like an auditory hallucination.

Celebrate to your heart's content. This will be your last laugh.

He hadn't understood it then.

He'd thought those words were nothing more than the tired bluster of a defeated general.

But now, the chill running down Jin Taekyung's spine foretold another crisis.

Could it be?

The tangled threads of information in his mind began to unravel one by one.

Ma Sanbao had never appeared on the battlefield, despite being an undeniably powerful asset—even if he was no match for the Blood Lord or the Grand Sorceress.

The Sword Saint and the Murim Alliance's elite had traveled thousands of *li*[3876] to Qinghai without even telling their own allies the truth.

And then there were the strange birds that had watched everything unfold before flying west.

Wait. If they're heading west…

No doubt about it.

Mount Kunlun.

That place, already in Dark Heaven's grasp, had to be the birds' destination.

At the same time, Jin Taekyung recalled one of the questions he still hadn't answered.

Why had Dark Heaven's enormous army, which had occupied Mount Kunlun before he and the reinforcements even set foot in Qinghai, remained so immovable?

Had the Blood Lord really made all these moves just to catch him and every other big fish in a single sweep of the net?

No. That wasn't all the Blood Lord was after from the start. It was just… they needed time, too.

Perhaps it was because his mind was already exhausted beyond its limits.

Or perhaps because he'd finally grasped the shape of the foreboding he'd felt.

His face had turned as pale as paper as he looked at the people surrounding him.

Without realizing it, Jin Taekyung let out the breath he'd been holding.

Along with two bitter words that had lingered on the tip of his tongue.

"…Moving Formation."

[3876] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

That was the answer Jin Taekyung had found.

It was one of the main reasons Dark Heaven's powerful army had hunkered down on Mount Kunlun—and the Blood Lord's last move, prepared in case things went wrong.

And Ma Sanbao, the hidden blade, would move as soon as he heard this news.

Through the Moving Formation newly inscribed somewhere on Mount Kunlun, he would pierce the allies' most vital point.

The very place called the Central Plains.

"We have to move. Right now. If we don't, the Central Plains—"

Jin Taekyung's voice trembled as he groaned.

His breath came hard, and his heart pounded.

Faces passed one after another through his wavering vision. Perhaps they shouldn't have come here today at all.

Especially the man who had been known as the Sword Saint for decades, and was now the Alliance Leader.

But—

"Yes. We have to move."

That was as far as Jin Taekyung could go.

Tap.

A hand suddenly touched the back of his neck.

In the same instant, Mae Jonghak struck him with a Pressure-Point Strike, swift as lightning. In an even voice, he continued:

"But this time, you're going to rest."

Jin Taekyung answered.

Or tried to.

No. Absolutely not. He couldn't rest now.

But despite his desperate resolve, his lips wouldn't move. Exhaustion and sleep washed over him, pressing down on his eyelids with the weight of ten thousand *geun*[3877].

Ah.

As his vision went dark in an instant, Jin Taekyung let go of consciousness, a voice ringing in his ears like an auditory hallucination.

"You've done well, my friend."

Qinghai is vast.

[3877] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand *geun* is 6,000 kg (about 13,200 lb).

But the wings of the strange birds, granted boundless vigor by death, were swift enough to make the distance between Xining and Mount Kunlun—more than several hundred *li*[3878]—seem insignificant.

And the shocking news brought by these exceptional messengers, unlike any seen before or since, reached Mount Kunlun's highest peak in less than a *shichen*[3879].

No—

It reached a certain corpse sorcerer who carried on the Maoshan Sect's legacy.

"…So that's what happened."

Ma Sanbao muttered to himself as he stared east, his gaze sinking deep.

The news was impossible to believe, but he had no choice.

More than a dozen strange birds had already relayed everything they'd seen and heard in vivid detail.

The outcome of a bloody battle that had raged without a break for half a day—and the presence of people he'd thought could never appear in Qinghai.

I owe the Blood Lord an apology. I thought he was just a man crazed by blood.

Ma Sanbao let out a quiet snort of laughter.

More than anyone, the Blood Lord had obsessed over Jin Taekyung. Yet by keeping one last move in reserve, he hadn't forgotten his most basic loyalty to the master who held his leash.

A final sword stroke that would lay waste to the Central Plains, now all but undefended.

And Ma Sanbao was willing to play that part.

"It's about time I left this wretched mountain."

Ma Sanbao rose from the grand chair and addressed his waiting subordinates.

"Let's go. To the Central Plains."

[3878] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

[3879] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Chapter 1134

The air on Mount Kunlun was heavy and cold that day.

Mist lay thick over the towering peaks. The creatures large and small that had once shared this beautiful wilderness with humans had long since vanished.

Only blood-red eyes glimmered through the dense mist, accompanied by eerie cries.

“Grrr.”

A savage growl came from between yellowed teeth.

The mountain lord[3880] that had ruled Mount Kunlun only a month ago lowered its body, now larger than it had been in life, to greet its master.

Around it, thousands of human demons surrounded Taiqing Hall—the very symbol of the Kunlun Sect—without leaving a single gap.

“Everyone has gathered, as you commanded.”

The report came from one of the hundred or so figures wrapped head to toe in jet-black robes. Ma Sanbao asked eagerly, “How many in all?”

“About five thousand. Three thousand of them are monsters.”

A smile touched Ma Sanbao’s lips.

“Then Mount Kunlun’s spiritual creatures must be extinct.”

Anyone familiar with the state of Murim who heard their purpose and conversation might have scoffed at such an absurd claim.

Five thousand was no small number, but even the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples, who had once blanketed the world in darkness, had failed to take the Central Plains.

Ma Sanbao had good reason to smile, though.

It’s enough. More than enough.

Ma Sanbao swept his sunken gaze over the subordinates packed in all around him.

The monsters’ blood-red eyes flashed without pause. The fanatics moved only at his command, little more than soulless puppets.

Fully prepared and waiting for Ma Sanbao’s orders, they deserved to be called a Demon Army. Comparing them to the mere Demonic Cult, now a ghost of the past, would be an insult.

But the greatest source of his confidence was the hundred or so corpse sorcerers before him, including the man in black.

None could compare to Ma Sanbao himself, but each was a true monster capable of leading an army so long as there were corpses to use.

He regarded them with satisfaction, then spoke.

[3880] *San-gun*, literally “mountain lord,” is a traditional epithet for a tiger.

"We'll split the army in two and move out."

"Forgive me, but has the plan changed?"

Ma Sanbao nodded at the black-clad man's cautious question.

Under the original plan, they would have split into seven groups and spread chaos across the land. But circumstances had changed.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak had appeared in Qinghai with no fewer than ten thousand elite troops from the Murim Alliance.

Who would've thought the Alliance Leader himself would bring reinforcements?

Ma Sanbao had stayed behind in case something like this happened. Even so, Mae Jonghak's arrival had surprised him as much as the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League's betrayal.

But the fact that Alliance Leader Mae Jonghak had left the Murim Alliance meant he must have left at least a minimal defense in Henan.

Of course, with its main force gone, it'll be nowhere near enough. Still, to prepare for any eventuality, we'd be wise not to spread ourselves too thin.

This was an opportunity Ma Sanbao had won with great difficulty—perhaps even a stroke of heavenly fortune. Given what the corpse sorcerers could do, his caution might be excessive. But he wanted the safest, surest course.

He meant to hold a place second only to one and above ten thousand in the world remade under the Lord of Heaven's rule. He had no intention of meeting a miserable end like the Blood Lord.

After careful thought, he had narrowed his targets to two places.

"Henan and Shanxi."

At his superior's voice, which broke the brief silence, the black-clad man bowed deeply.

"As you command. An excellent decision."

With the Jin Family of Taiyuan away, Shanxi Province was all but an ownerless mountain. Henan, meanwhile, had to be taken for both its symbolic importance to Murim and its strategic location.

With Mae Jonghak gone, this was the perfect chance to seize it.

Henan and Shanxi also shared a border. Should anything go wrong, the two forces could support each other.

"If I give you two thousand troops and half the sorcerers, can you take Shanxi Province within seven days and nights?"

Shanxi Province had grown stronger by the day since the Jin Family of Taiyuan united it.

The black-clad man answered without hesitation. His force might number a *mere* two thousand now, but with *dozens* of corpse sorcerers, it would multiply without end.

“Four days will suffice.”

“And if I include Hebei?”

“Give me ten days. I’ll return leading an army of a hundred thousand.”

Ma Sanbao’s smile deepened at the ready answer.

“I’ll remember that promise.”

At that very moment—

Sssaaaa.

Faint strands of light began to rise from the ground.

The Moving Formation the Grand Sorceress had installed during her stay on Mount Kunlun—no, the Magic Formation—was activating under the hands of the sorcerers who had remained with Ma Sanbao.

Vroooom.

Two enormous circles of light spread outward, growing by the second until they enveloped everyone.

Ma Sanbao felt a mysterious surge of energy from every direction and trembled with elation.

I’ll end it all in one stroke. With my own two hands.

No one who knew him could deny that his confidence was justified.

He was the most powerful corpse sorcerer to carry on the Maoshan Sect’s legacy. As a martial artist, he was also a Supreme Peak master who could stand shoulder to shoulder with the Ten Kings.

With the Three Saints, Jin Taekyung, and Jeok Cheongang all absent, nothing in the Central Plains’ Murim frightened him.

Sword Saint, you of all people shouldn’t have left.

Whatever defenses they had prepared, this force could cut through the heart of the Central Plains in an instant.

By the time word of its arrival reached the enemy, the army would number tens of thousands rather than thousands.

An immortal army whose ranks would fill again no matter how many times its soldiers were killed.

Today, the course of history changes.

The world would remember forever that Ma Sanbao had been there for the first step of a grand new history that would endure a thousand years.

Fwoosh!

A brilliant flash washed his vision white. Smiling, Ma Sanbao closed his eyes and yielded to the mysterious force pulling his spirit and body toward a distant place.

He imagined the great strides he would take, one after another, and the mighty trail they would carve across the world.

Paht.

The change was instantaneous.

The air and wind around him were different now. Instinctively, Ma Sanbao knew the Grand Sorceress's Magic Formation had carried him and some three thousand of his subordinates to the promised place.

At last, it begins.

Thrilled to be taking that great first step, Ma Sanbao opened his eyes.

Or rather, he tried to.

Crunch—splat!

A gruesome sound of flesh being torn rang out, and something hot and sticky covered his face before he could open them.

"…!"

The smell of blood seeped deep into his nostrils, all too familiar.

It felt as though the world had stopped. Ma Sanbao struggled to lift his trembling eyelids.

Then he saw clearly what else he had failed to realize.

Thump. Splatter.

In some nameless, remote mountain valley where even the moonlight didn't reach, large and small figures crumpled like bundles of straw without so much as a dying cry.

Ma Sanbao could neither move nor stop it. The survivors around him were no different.

All they could do was stare blankly at the deaths of fully two thousand of their comrades, felled before they could take their first step in Henan.

Their bodies had become one with rocks and trees rather than falling to blades or spears. They lay dead in hideous, unnatural shapes.

"What… What in the world…"

Just then, an unexpected answer reached Ma Sanbao's ears as he muttered in a dazed voice, as if under a spell.

"What do you think? Exactly what you're looking at."

A calm voice sounded from the darkness.

Ma Sanbao whipped his head toward it like lightning and stared.

How long had that man been there?

Several dozen *jang*[3881] away, a middle-aged man stood atop a hill that ringed the basin like a wall. He looked down over the fear and confusion below.

No—he was looking at Ma Sanbao.

"Good to meet you. I mean that. I was so worried you wouldn't come that I could hardly stand it."

[3881] A *jang* is ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m or 9.94 ft.

The man slowly surveyed Ma Sanbao, frozen stiff as a statue, and the subordinates who had survived. He smacked his lips.

"I can't say I'm not a little disappointed…but I suppose that was enough of a welcome. Don't you think?"

Ma Sanbao did not answer.

He couldn't. Right then, it was all he could do to grasp the word filling his blank mind.

A trap…!

Yes. This was a trap, and a meticulously prepared one.

And the refined-looking middle-aged man smiling on the hill was unmistakably the one who had laid a trap in the Moving Formation the Grand Sorceress had carved deep into a remote valley in Henan that no one ever visited.

A hunter who had set the simplest, surest, most horrific trap of all.

"Don't glare at me like that. I'm the disappointed one. If I'd known the Moving Formation's exact range, I could have finished you all in one stroke."

The man even let out a theatrical sigh. Ma Sanbao felt his blood boil.

"You'll regret that you didn't. I'll tear you and every last member of your household to pieces."

The man had not introduced himself, but Ma Sanbao already knew who he was.

The portrait Ma Sanbao had seen during his years in the East Depot and the pure-white fan in the man's hand left little doubt.

"Crouching Dragon Guest, Zhuge Feng."

Zhuge Feng, the current Family Head of the Zhuge Clan, widened his eyes.

"Oh? You know me?"

"I do. I remembered you. After today, though, I'll forget you."

Ma Sanbao drew up the qi within him.

The trap had cost him more than half his subordinates, but the corpse sorcerers—his most important force—had suffered little damage.

Once the fighting began, there would be more corpses.

Whatever Zhuge Feng had prepared, Ma Sanbao was certain he would be the one to leave this valley alive at sunrise.

At least, he was until a familiar face appeared behind Zhuge Feng.

"Then you remember me, too. Don't you, Eunuch Ma?"

A chill passed through Ma Sanbao's chest.

How could he forget a face he had seen for decades? Or the resonant voice of the veteran general who had protected the imperial household through every peril?

But Baek Yeon, the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard and the imperial household's greatest master, was not the only reason Ma Sanbao was shaken.

If the man who served as the imperial household’s sword and shield was here, it meant something else.

Scuff.

A slender figure stepped out from behind the burly veteran.

He looked down at his former servant with the haughty gaze only someone born to noble blood could possess.

No—at the criminal for the ages who had dared to overthrow the imperial household.

“So, was playing traitor worth it?”

At the Son of Heaven’s question, Ma Sanbao groaned.

Chapter 1135

On a hill washed in faint moonlight, his sudden appearance seemed utterly out of place.

Not just to Ma Sanbao. To all of them.

Then the voice that slipped between his pale lips revealed the source of that unease.

“So, was playing traitor worth it?”

His tone was as calm as still water. Yet beneath it lay an authority only a ruler could possess.

It was dignity.

Neither his black robe, blending into the darkness, nor the bamboo hat pulled low over his face could conceal it. He needed no elaborate imperial robe or crown of hanging beads. That dignity was his by birth.

“It’s been a long time, Palace Attendant Ma.”

He spoke down to Ma Sanbao as if looking at him from a dizzying height.

Ma Sanbao stifled a groan at the Son of Heaven’s unexpected appearance, then spoke in a low voice.

“What brings Your Majesty all the way here?”

“I came to take care of some urgent business.”

“Was it important enough to leave the Imperial Capital?”

“How curious. Why don’t you think I prepared thoroughly enough to leave the capital?”

“…!”

“A mere traitor like you needn’t worry about the capital’s safety. Not while the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac are guarding it.”

The Son of Heaven fixed his deep, sunken gaze on Ma Sanbao, who had fallen silent.

The Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac.

Twelve Supreme Peak masters who protected the imperial household.

Though few remained after the rebellion led by the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord, now that they knew the Moving Formation’s location, those masters and the Imperial Guards under their command were more than enough.

Provided, of course, that the enemy attacked the capital.

“Enough bluffing. If you’d planned to strike the capital in the first place, you and I wouldn’t be facing each other here. Isn’t that right?”

The remark hit home. Ma Sanbao quietly licked his dry lips.

The Son of Heaven was right.

The instant he received word from the strange birds, Ma Sanbao had erased the Imperial Capital from his mind.

If he captured the capital and took the Son of Heaven, he could bring the world to its knees. But the Murim of the Central Plains, already left with a massive gap in its defenses, was far more tempting prey.

Why take the hard road when a faster, easier one lay open?

And that assumption had been Ma Sanbao's greatest blunder.

"…Not bad, Zhu Di."

Speaking the Son of Heaven's personal name was high treason in itself.

Ma Sanbao didn't care. He had never once considered himself the Son of Heaven's subject.

Now, with nowhere left to retreat, he wanted an answer to the one question that remained.

"How did you find this place?"

It wasn't the Son of Heaven who answered, but Zhuge Feng.

"Two years."

"What?"

"Ah, don't misunderstand. I wasn't calling you a bitch. I know you're a eunuch, but you certainly look like a man, not a woman."

Zhuge Feng smiled at Ma Sanbao's stiffened face and continued.

"Since we discovered the Moving Formation, we've searched the whole world with a fine-tooth comb. Not quite two years, actually. More like a year and a half."

"…!"

"Oh, yes. When I started this madness, I had exactly the look you have now. My retainers looked even worse. My seniors, the Sword King and Fist King, tried to strangle me. The late Blade King was worse still."

Zhuge Feng rubbed the back of his neck at the memory. Ma Sanbao stared at him in disbelief.

"You searched for them? You even brought in the Ten Kings?"

"I understand how you feel. But what else could we have done?"

With a sigh, Zhuge Feng gently waved the feather fan in his hand.

The first month or two had been hell.

No, worse. At least hell had sulfur fires burning here and there. They had felt as if they were adrift in the middle of an endless ocean.

But it hadn't taken long to find their first result.

"We found one after three months. Hidden deep in Mount Huang in Anhui. Fortunately, the search went much faster after that."

The entire operation had been conducted in the utmost secrecy, using only people who had passed the Hidden Shadow Pavilion's screening.

Membership in the Nine Sects and One Gang or the Five Great Families made no difference. Not even a Sect Leader was exempt.

They answered to one person alone—the Alliance Leader—and faithfully carried out their assigned tasks.

Myriad-Mile Pursuit, Gung Gibang's master and the Beggars' Sect Leader, mobilized every trusted subordinate he could alongside the Lower District Sect to look for places where a Moving Formation might be hidden. The Zhuge Clan's and Hidden Shadow Pavilion's strategists used what they brought back to narrow down the locations.

"No matter how difficult a problem is, you can find the answer once you know how to solve it. Fortunately, finding the Moving Formations worked the same way."

Even for Zhuge Feng, renowned as a prodigy since childhood, it had been an extraordinarily difficult problem. But before long, he worked out the method.

He looked for places few people visited, where qi flowed with unusual strength, where there was room for at least several hundred people, and where no grass grew.

Zhuge Feng selected sites that met those conditions. Once he made his choice, renowned formation masters from the Zhuge Clan and masters with exceptional Qi Sense went to verify them in person.

Supreme Peak masters such as the Azure Sky Sword King, Grand Family Head of the Namgung Family, and the Fist King were among them.

"But no matter how hard we tried, we didn't have enough people. We had a fair number, but searching the vast Nine Provinces[3882] thoroughly while keeping the secret was beyond us."

Not a single mistake could be allowed.

Even the sturdiest wall could begin to collapse with one tiny crack.

In that sense, each Moving Formation was a vast powder keg. A single one going off could set the whole world ablaze.

Then, a few months ago, help came from an unexpected source. Zhuge Feng could finally put the last of his worries to rest.

"I heard a certain person of high standing told the Alliance Leader he'd do anything he could to help. And he was a tremendous help."

At Zhuge Feng's words, the "person of high standing" spoke up.

"Surely you mean the person of *highest* standing?"

"Ah, forgive my discourtesy, Your Majesty."

"Of course. I'll forgive anything short of high treason."

Ma Sanbao had listened blankly to their exchange. Now he clenched his teeth.

[3882] The Nine Provinces is a traditional Chinese expression for the whole realm, not a count of current administrative provinces.

They got me. Completely.

The enemies in the Central Plains must have waited for this very moment.

Though they could have shut down the Moving Formations they found, they had left them alone and laid a perfect trap instead.

They had let their prey come running, mouths watering, so they could root out their last remaining concern.

“Is that how you dealt with the advance party, too?”

Zhuge Feng gently waved his feather fan.

“Huashan wiped them out as soon as they arrived. The Murim Alliance’s elite, led by the Alliance Leader, took their place.”

“Our information clearly said they’d joined those two bandit bastards.”

“What’s so hard about that? We only needed a similar number of people dressed in black. Word was bound to spread on its own. And it did.”

The ten thousand fanatics who were supposed to join the Green Forest Alliance and the Yangtze River Channel League had died before they ever boarded the league’s ships.

And the Seafaring King, Pa Ryun, had kept the truth thoroughly concealed.

Even subduing his disciple, Ship-Fire Boy Mu Song, had been a way to protect the secret. If Mu Song, who hadn’t been told the plan, acted on his sense of justice, he might expose the fact that the people aboard the rear ships—deliberately kept separate—belonged to the Murim Alliance.

“But then what about the fleet of hundreds of ships the river bandits destroyed…?”

Ma Sanbao trailed off.

The Son of Heaven’s cold smile had given him the answer to his last question.

“I see. So that’s what happened.”

At last, Ma Sanbao understood everything. A hollow laugh escaped him.

He had forgotten for a moment.

Beneath the Son of Heaven’s pale skin, instead of hot, red blood, ran cold iron and blood.

“The palace’s underground prison must be empty by now. Zhu Di, was this your doing?”

The Son of Heaven answered evenly.

“There were so many traitors eating away at the nation that killing them one by one became a chore. They paid a price of their own, so it wasn’t such a bad end for them.”

After the Eastern Heaven Demon Lord’s rebellion came a purge without precedent in the Great Nation’s history.

The Son of Heaven had made an offer to the many prisoners who survived it and still awaited punishment.

They could die with their families, as the law required, or spend the rest of their lives as slaves. Or they could lift even a little of the stain from their family names.

Naturally, most chose the last option.

Freed from the chains and restraints that bound them, they accepted spears and blades with trembling hands and boarded the Great Nation's ships.

All the while, they repeated the Son of Heaven's promise to themselves: because of their choice, someone of their blood would survive to carry on the family name.

"Right. No wonder it went more smoothly than I expected. Rotten as their forces were, it was strange for them to suffer a defeat that crushing."

They hadn't been trained soldiers. Even with hundreds of ships and cannons, their annihilation had been inevitable.

Now that he knew the full extent of the audacious plan—one only the Son of Heaven could have carried out, throwing all those prisoners to the enemy as bait—Ma Sanbao could only laugh.

No. He had to laugh.

A hollow laugh, as though he had given up, was the only way to conceal his last chance.

Not yet. It's not over yet.

His mouth smiled. His eyes did not.

Ma Sanbao quickly swept his sunken gaze around.

On the hills encircling them, countless arrowheads poked quietly through the thick grass. He sensed his subordinates holding their breath, waiting for his command.

They outnumber us at least five to one. Maybe more.

It didn't matter.

If he could capture just one of the enemies who had prepared so thoroughly, he could turn this desperate situation around.

No—he might do more than that. He might seize everything.

That was what the Son of Heaven represented.

Besides, Ma Sanbao and his men had no other choice.

"Now—!"

It all happened in an instant.

Ma Sanbao's mighty shout as he kicked off the ground and shot upward.

The taut bowstrings released their arrows all at once.

And—

Whoosh!

Before the countless arrows that couldn't keep up with his lightning speed had even finished sweeping across the ground, a low whistle of air split through the space above Ma Sanbao's head.

No Shadow…!

Ma Sanbao clenched his teeth at the masked figure who had appeared in his path.

It was him.

Ma Sanbao had never seen his face clearly, but he knew of the Son of Heaven's hidden bodyguard.

The imperial household's greatest assassin, who never even revealed his shadow, was bringing down a dagger wrapped in Force beneath the faint moonlight.

Just as Ma Sanbao had expected.

Shhk!

With a gruesome sound of torn flesh, the blade sank into his forearm.

Ma Sanbao paid it no mind. He thrust out his half-severed left hand and struck No Shadow.

Crack!

No Shadow went flying from the force of the blow. Ma Sanbao drove internal energy into the tips of his feet and released it.

Boom!

He shot down toward the hill like a falling star.

The White Illusion Jiangshi Art, grown stronger still since the bloody battle at the imperial palace, let him forget pain and fear.

"Zhu Di!"

Ma Sanbao roared.

A dozen or so arrows shot from his blind spots and buried themselves across his body. Zhuge Feng and Baek Yeon blocked his path. But his corpse-gray eyes remained fixed on one person alone.

The Son of Heaven, his pale face still bearing the unmistakable signs of illness, just as it had the last time Ma Sanbao saw him.

Shhk! Thud!

Crack!

There was no blood left to spill from a body already little different from a jiangshi. Only chunks of flesh and pieces of bone flew through the air.

But his desperate will remained.

Slash!

Baek Yeon's crescent-bladed polearm bit into Ma Sanbao's left shoulder and sliced diagonally through his upper body.

Crack!

Ma Sanbao's one remaining hand finally closed around what he wanted.

The Son of Heaven's throat.

"Everyone, stop."

Silence fell.

Before the Son of Heaven could draw the sword at his waist, Ma Sanbao had seized and immobilized him with lightning speed. He smiled faintly.

Then he whispered into the ear of the Son of Heaven, whose pressure points he had struck.

“Thank you. You came all the way here yourself, so—”

Thud.

Ma Sanbao blinked.

Why?

How could the Son of Heaven move after his pressure points had been struck?

And why, now that they were face-to-face, was the Son of Heaven’s skin so much like his own?

“…You. Don’t tell me—”

Crack.

The Son of Heaven slowly twisted the hand that had pierced the center of Ma Sanbao’s chest and spoke.

“A few months ago, someone gave me a great gift. Something you know well.”

“…!”

“I thought long and hard about it. It was a blessing, but every bit as much a curse.”

The Son of Heaven’s deliberation had not lasted long, though. His only remaining blood relative, the sole heir who would inherit the realm, had made him a request.

“He told me to live a thousand years. Not as the Son of Heaven, but as family—as someone he wanted to stay with for a long time.”

Moved by Prince Shangshan Zhu Bao’s sincerity—no, Imperial Younger Brother Zhu Bao’s—the Son of Heaven made his choice.

Even if it meant breaking a taboo. Even if he might one day regret it, he would stay with his younger brother for as long as he was allowed.

And that choice had brought them to this moment.

“Now I understand why Jin Taekyung gave me the White Illusion Jiangshi Art. It wasn’t just for me… It was for my brother, who would otherwise be left alone again.”

At that moment—

“By the law of the Great Nation, I punish this traitor.”

Crack!

The Son of Heaven’s voice was the last Ma Sanbao would ever hear. The world before his eyes went black.

Chapter 1136

No one could survive having their heart crushed.

That simple truth held even for someone who had mastered the White Illusion Jiangshi Art, one of the foremost among the world's countless monstrous martial arts and supreme techniques.

Thud.

His body crumpled like a rotten old tree.

The Son of Heaven looked down in silence at the traitor who had finally met his end. Then he pulled his hand from deep inside the man's chest and spoke.

"Commander."

The brief call contained no instruction, but it was enough for Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard.

"At your command."

The reverence he showed the Son of Heaven, who had personally executed the traitor, came as naturally as flowing water.

So did the crescent-bladed polearm that flashed downward.

Shhk!

Flesh and bone parted with a chilling slice.

Baek Yeon beheaded the traitor in a single stroke, then speared the severed head on the tip of his polearm and held it upright.

The traitor's eyes had frozen wide open before they could close. Now they would watch the scene below the hill to the very end.

Shh-shh-shh-shh-shhk!

It wasn't just one person who thought the sky had suddenly darkened.

Thousands of Imperial Guards, every one of them an elite chosen to serve the Son of Heaven, loosed their powerful bows at once. Their arrows, propelled by internal energy, covered the sky and rained down with tremendous speed and force.

They fell upon the enemies struggling desperately in the shallow basin dozens of *jang*[3883] away.

Thwup-thwup-thwup!

"Gaaah!"

Blood and screams burst forth without pause.

At the start of the battle, many of the fanatics had taken Temporary Strength Pills. They swung Sword Energy as they closed the distance, but even at full speed, they could not reach the hill.

"Open."

[3883] A *jang* is a traditional length of ten *ja*, approximately 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Fwoosh.

At Zhuge Feng's quiet command, a strange energy drifting through the air rose like heat haze.

Thick fog swallowed the base of the hill in an instant.

The fanatics fell into confusion at the sight of illusions unlike any they had seen before. Then a second command rang out.

"Close."

Clack.

With a cold metallic sound, countless hidden weapons and arrowheads emerged all around them.

The Zhuge Clan's mechanisms and formations, hailed as the finest in the world, had finally revealed themselves.

The result was a horrific death.

Fwoosh, splat!

The fog turned red.

Everything inside was pierced, cut, and smashed to pieces.

From between rocks, beneath the earth, and even the knots in trees, traps sprang from gaps no one would have thought to watch. In moments, the fanatics were driven to their deaths.

A few escaped the fog by using their allies' corpses as shields, but Zhuge Feng had prepared more than that.

Fwoosh!

The Zhuge Clan retainers numbered a mere hundred. The terrifying rate of fire of their Zhuge Repeating Crossbows was more than enough to make up for their small numbers.

Far more than enough.

Crack-crack-crack!

In the blink of an eye, riddled bodies piled up.

The battle that had begun in the dead of night was still going on, but what unfolded before everyone's eyes made even the word *battle* seem inadequate.

A slaughter this one-sided could hardly be called a battle.

And this hellscape was not unfolding only in Henan.

"Looks like it'll be a long night."

Zhuge Feng answered the Son of Heaven's sudden murmur.

"And soon, the sun will rise."

He was right.

No matter how long the night, day would come. Another day would begin beneath a sun as bright as ever—or brighter.

Tonight, they would eliminate one of the great threats hanging over the Central Plains.

"Though a wise man should never be too certain… I, Zhuge Feng, have no doubt."

He had put everything he had into this plan. For a long time, Zhuge Feng had waited, deceiving not only the enemy but even his allies.

All for today. For this very moment.

"Wherever the traitors go, they won't escape death."

Zhuge Feng spoke with conviction.

They had gathered each province's elite at every Moving Formation they had found. Wherever Dark Heaven's dagger was aimed, its forces would be dead before the night was over.

That was especially true of Shanxi, which Zhuge Feng had judged, alongside Henan, to be the enemy's most likely target.

A giant called the Azure Sky Sword King was leading the forces there.

"It is all thanks to Your Majesty's help."

The Son of Heaven gave a quiet laugh at Zhuge Feng's respectful thanks.

"Is that so? I wonder if the Commander agrees."

Baek Yeon, standing beside him, answered without hesitation.

"Of course not. They did all the hard work. The Imperial House only lent a hand at the end."

Zhuge Feng's mouth fell open at the unexpected answer, but the Son of Heaven's smile deepened.

"Why?"

"Don't ask when you already know, Your Majesty."

"That's a rather irreverent way to speak. You couldn't even stop the traitor just now."

Baek Yeon frowned.

"That was because Your Majesty kept insisting you would deal with him yourself. What, are you going to strip me of my office?"

"That would be inconvenient. I still need you."

"Your Majesty's wisdom grows deeper by the day. As your servant, I could not be happier. Though after all the trouble I go through, it's a shame my salary hasn't budged in years."

"My, my. Is that any way for the Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard to speak? We've recovered the traitors' wealth, so I'll double your salary."

"Perhaps I'm getting old. My armor feels heavy today."

"Triple it."

"I am overwhelmed by Your Majesty's grace, Your Majesty."

Baek Yeon gave a crisp salute, then glanced up at the Son of Heaven.

As if on cue, sovereign and subject burst out laughing. They laughed so heartily that Zhuge Feng, watching the absurd exchange, was left speechless.

But the man born of the noblest bloodline in the world did not mind in the slightest.

The old general who had guarded the Imperial House for decades had every right to speak that way. Besides, everything he had said was true.

“Yes. The Commander is right. I only lent a hand at the end. That isn’t enough to repay even a tenth of the debt I owe.”

The Son of Heaven smiled at the bewildered Zhuge Feng.

In the past, when life had been like walking on thin ice, danger had lurked on every side and he had fought against illness. He had not been able to smile like this.

But now things were different.

No—Jin Taekyung had made them different. He had changed everything and restored the laughter the Son of Heaven had lost long ago.

The Son of Heaven knew that better than anyone. He could not accept Zhuge Feng’s praise, even as a courtesy.

He was alive because of Jin Taekyung. The realm could weather another crisis because of him, too.

“It’s troubling. How am I supposed to repay a debt that keeps growing?”

At the Son of Heaven’s rueful murmur, Zhuge Feng’s gaze grew serious.

“Perhaps… we’re all wondering the same thing.”

The three of them turned to look west.

They could see nothing there, yet each seemed to glimpse one man somewhere thousands of *li*[3884] away. Like the faint light beginning to spread over their shoulders.

“The sun’s risen.”

“Yes. Day is breaking.”

The Son of Heaven blinked as though he were seeing light for the first time.

Perhaps it was only his imagination.

The basin lay silent amid pools of blood, thousands of corpses piled like mountains. Yet the sunlight reaching across them seemed brighter than ever.

“Bright.”

Darkness scattered. Light blazed.

The Son of Heaven fervently hoped the countless days ahead would be the same.

And that Jin Taekyung’s fate, which would surely once again leave him standing at the edge of life and death, casting everything he had aside, would be bright as well.

[3884] A Chinese *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

“Great Ming.”

With that new name for the nation, one that would light the way ahead for everyone, the Son of Heaven of the Great Ming Empire let out the breath swelling in his chest.

“Baek Yeon.”

“Your orders, Your Majesty?”

“I think I’ll have to quadruple your salary. What lies ahead will be difficult.”

“What do you mean…?”

“I will not return to the palace.”

“…!”

“Tell every person in the realm: I will not sit upon the throne until those vile traitors lurking beyond the desert have been rooted out.”

The old general stared at the Son of Heaven, eyes wide. Then he smiled and knelt on one knee.

“I, Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, accept Your Majesty’s imperial decree.”

That day, countless messenger pigeons and mounted couriers crossed the skies and lands of the realm.

Carried by wings and hooves, the imperial decree spread across the realm in just a few days.

No—it shook the realm to its core.

Murim, the common people, even the government.

“By imperial decree!”

Messengers posted proclamations bearing the imperial seal wherever they went. At last, everyone learned of the blade that had been poised at their throats.

And of the one-sided, momentous victory that had begun and ended in a single night.

But victory was not all the Son of Heaven wished to announce.

He would lead an expedition himself.

Back when he was known as the Fourth Prince, the Son of Heaven had already been judged to have the makings of a conqueror. Now, under the new name of Great Ming, he ordered the Imperial Guards to assemble, and his destination was exactly what everyone had expected.

Xinjiang.

The former stronghold of the Demonic Cult, beyond the scorching desert.

The spearheads of the whole realm were aimed at the leader of the traitors, who dared to call himself the Lord of Heaven.

Chapter 1137

Many people call the Central Plains the center of the world, but the phrase has a more precise meaning.

The true center of the world is the Imperial Capital.

Because that is where the Son of Heaven resides—the father of all his people, wielding absolute authority.

And in that same sense, Henan, which had shared in Murim's earliest beginnings and history, could no longer be called the Murim Alliance's headquarters.

What mattered was not the place, but the people.

The symbolism attached to a place was created by people.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak felt that keenly through the letters arriving each day from every corner of the realm.

He had also discovered that the higher the piles of paperwork grew, the more desperately he longed for a visitor.

"Come in."

Beyond the firmly shut door, the owner of a faint presence hesitated briefly before entering the study.

"Pardon me for a moment…"

The visitor trailed off, looking from Mae Jonghak's sunken eyes to the piles of papers filling the room.

"Hmm. You seem busy."

"It's all right. Have a cup of tea before you go."

"No, I'll come back later—urk!"

Whoosh! Grab!

Mae Jonghak moved in a flash.

Using Huashan's secret technique, Dark Fragrance Drift, he crossed the room in an instant and seized the visitor's sleeve.

He spoke with desperate longing in his eyes and voice.

"Have a cup of tea before you go."

"…"

"Please."

He looked ready to grab the man by the collar if the sleeve wasn't enough.

The visitor sensed a disturbing madness in Mae Jonghak's glittering eyes and swallowed nervously.

"All right, all right. Let go and we'll talk."

"If you're lying, I'll resent you even after I'm dead."

"Why go that far…? Besides, what good would resenting me do? You'd be dead."

"That's true. What kind of tea would you like?"

"Longjing[3885], please."

"It's the only kind I have. Just drink that."

Worried the man might change his mind, Mae Jonghak hurriedly let go of his sleeve. The visitor watched Mae Jonghak prepare the teapot and thought to himself:

Then why did you even ask…?

Of course, he already knew. With some people, the more you tried to understand them, the more you only hurt yourself.

It was a lesson he'd learned over the past few months with a certain madman.

"…You're the spitting image of him. I could've sworn I heard he wasn't your biological grandson."

"Hm? What did you say?"

"Nothing. Just talking to myself."

"I understand. The older you get, the more you talk to yourself."

It was hard to believe this conversation was between a fresh-faced young man and a boy who looked several years younger. But appearances weren't everything.

The Slaughter Saint knew that better than almost anyone.

"So the Alliance Leader does it too. I suppose we're all much the same."

"Hm? Much the same?"

"Didn't you just say people talk to themselves more as they get older?"

"Oh, that. I meant people in general. I've talked to myself since I was a child, so I can't say I relate."

"…Is the tea going to take much longer?"

Just as the Slaughter Saint felt his energy rapidly draining away, Mae Jonghak finally set a steaming cup on the table.

"Drink. It isn't my tea, but the aroma should be quite good."

Mae Jonghak was right.

Perhaps because it was the tea enjoyed by a man who had been a City Lord, both its aroma and quality were excellent.

The man, who had committed countless acts of corruption, had vanished like dew on the execution grounds. But his tea leaves—and his lavish study—remained.

The study now served as the Murim Alliance's temporary Alliance Leader's Hall.

"I hope I'm not taking up too much of your precious time."

The Slaughter Saint glanced at the towering piles of papers, which looked ready to collapse at any moment. Mae Jonghak tilted his hot teacup and answered.

[3885] Longjing, or Dragon Well, is a Chinese green tea.

“Time is always precious. If we’d lost the battle seven days ago, I wouldn’t be enjoying this luxury.”

Watching the wisps of steam rise like heat haze, the Slaughter Saint murmured as if to himself.

“Seven days. Has it really been that long?”

Mae Jonghak wasn’t the only one who’d been busy.

The past week had left everyone, including the Slaughter Saint, scarcely a moment to rest. They’d had to begin dealing with the aftermath before they could recover from the battle’s physical and mental toll.

And Mae Jonghak already knew that the Slaughter Saint, busy treating the wounded, wouldn’t have come without a reason.

“You’ve had time to enjoy the aroma. Well?”

Naturally, he wasn’t asking whether the man liked the tea.

The Slaughter Saint watched Mae Jonghak smile. Then he stirred the internal energy sleeping deep within him.

Wooooom.

A wave spread outward, making the air tremble.

Only when an invisible barrier had enclosed them both, shutting out sound, did the Slaughter Saint speak.

“I came to see you about the matter I mentioned before.”

Mae Jonghak’s eyes turned grave.

“Since you came yourself… I take it the news isn’t good.”

The Slaughter Saint’s voice was heavy.

“That’s right.”

“You couldn’t find it after all?”

“Based on what we know so far.”

That left a faint possibility, but Mae Jonghak looked doubtful. So did the Slaughter Saint, who had said it.

As soon as the battle ended, the surviving martial artists, government troops, and countless civilians had thrown themselves into dealing with the aftermath.

More than a hundred thousand people on both sides had been killed or wounded. If all those searching had failed to find *it* in seven days, the chances of finding it later were slim.

“Further searches would be pointless.”

“You mean…”

“I’m not saying we should stop entirely. Keep looking, but cut down on the manpower spent on it.”

The Slaughter Saint nodded quietly.

Mae Jonghak was right. He, too, thought it better to focus on what lay ahead than to keep pouring effort into a search with so little hope of success.

And yet, the unease weighing on him remained.

“I’m worried too. But…”

Seeing the shadow on the Slaughter Saint’s face, Mae Jonghak continued.

“The tide has already turned. The blades of the Central Plains—no, of the whole realm—have finally come together.”

Mae Jonghak reached out. Dozens of missives rose from between the piles of papers and flew toward them.

From the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes to the Four Seas and Five Lakes, they had crossed vast stretches of sky and land to reach Xining. Each bore a different official seal, but all ended with the same four words.

“Exterminate the Demons and Set Heaven Right.”

Exterminate the demons and set heaven right.

It was the banner the old Murim Alliance had raised, and now those four words united the realm.

Even the empire, newly reborn under the name Great Ming, had embraced them.

“They’re coming. For the same single purpose as us.”

Seven days had passed since their decisive victory after a fierce battle.

But those who had spent the time since living each day as if it were a mere moment were not only the people in Xining.

On the day rivers of blood had flowed through Xining, enemy corpses had piled up like mountains in Henan Province and Shanxi Province.

Ma Sanbao’s head had been taken back to the Imperial Capital. The rest of his body had been torn apart and scattered across the realm.

The Azure Sky Sword King, who had already completed his preparations, had wiped out the enemy without suffering a single casualty. The dozen or so remaining Moving Formations had been shut down before daybreak.

As long as the Demon-Sealing Formation cast by the Zhuge Clan’s formation masters remained in place, the danger posed by the Moving Formations had effectively been eliminated.

It was the Demon-Sealing Formation that had allowed them to seal the first rift in Hubei, after all.

That newfound safety had lit a fuse that had long lain cold.

Under the banners of the Imperial House and the Murim Alliance, the westward advance had begun in earnest.

At the Son of Heaven’s decree that he would personally lead an army against the rebels, a hundred thousand elite Imperial Guards assembled. Martial artists rallied too, led by the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families.

Nor did it end there.

Even common people with no power of their own organized volunteer militias to stand against injustice. At last, the will of the realm had come together.

"Xinjiang. We can end everything in that accursed land beyond the desert."

Mae Jonghak spoke in a low but powerful voice.

"The only way to stop this wheel from turning is to defeat the Lord of Heaven."

The beginning and end of it all. Its very center.

That was the Lord of Heaven.

An absolute being who had never once shown his true form, yet whose immense shadow covered the realm.

But now that the realm had joined forces and pointed its blades at the Lord of Heaven, heaven's will was already on their side.

Or so they believed.

...But why?

For some reason, the words "Son of Heaven" filled him with an inexplicable sense of foreboding.

He raised his teacup, though the tea had gone cold.

Perhaps he hoped to hide the unease lodged deep in his heart.

As he drank, he turned over the other reason he had come to see Mae Jonghak.

I still can't make sense of what the Bow Saint said and did back then.

More precisely, he doubted anyone could have.

That was why the Slaughter Saint found it even harder to shake from his mind.

She had stood by, almost indifferent, even when Jin Taekyung was in mortal danger. Her words and actions had been impossible to read, as though she had some purpose no one else knew about.

She's hiding something. I'm certain of it.

But seven days had passed, and the Slaughter Saint still had no answer.

The Bow Saint had seldom shown herself since the battle, and Jin Taekyung had yet to regain consciousness.

What should I do?

Still deep in thought, the Slaughter Saint drained his tea.

He was about to speak to Mae Jonghak, who was watching him in silence as though he had sensed something.

Or tried to.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

Heavy, hurried footsteps sounded. A huge man burst into the study.

Crash!

He smashed the door to pieces and shouted.

“Alliance Leader! Taishan saw it! With my own two eyes!”

The Slaughter Saint recognized the familiar face, sighed, and closed his mouth. Mae Jonghak felt his brief respite come to an end and answered mournfully.

“I see. What did you see?”

At Taishan’s next words, both men’s eyes widened.

“The Pavilion Master! The Pavilion Master woke up!”

“…!”

“…!”

Chapter 1138

Jin Taekyung blinked quietly.

Where was he?

Everything was dark and hazy.

His small body sped forward on outstretched wings, but his senses were so dull they seemed to belong to someone else. He could barely feel the wind brushing over him.

That's right.

He was a bird now.

Soon he would emerge from these damp, hazy clouds swirling all around him.

No—right now.

Whoosh.

With one powerful flap of his wings, the clouds that had filled the air around Jin Taekyung like bars vanished.

A night sky so dark it looked cold opened before him.

Brilliant, multicolored flames painted the vast sky.

Boom-boom-boom!

Explosions erupted without warning, all at once, swallowing the night sky.

From a distance, the sight might have seemed beautiful.

But with a bird's keen eyesight, Jin Taekyung could see what lay beyond the dazzling lights.

Countless fighter jets tore through the sky, bursting through the compressed air. Bullets and beams of light streamed without pause from the ground and the sky.

And—

Shriek!

Gigantic monsters flew straight through that dense web of fire.

—Kieeeek!

With chilling roars, more monsters than the eye could count crossed the dark sky.

Killing intent tangled with killing intent. Every thunderous blast was followed by someone's death.

Kwa-gwa-gwang!

A blinding flash swallowed the sky.

Jin Taekyung was only a bird. All he could do was stare, dumbfounded, at the humans and monsters falling helplessly like scattered embers amid the ceaseless clash of steel and magic.

Then a sense that the whole world had gone dark seized him, and he looked up.

Hssssss.

At first, he thought it was a storm cloud.

A huge, dark cloud, big enough to blot out the moonlight.

But it wasn't.

It was a wing.

A wing so enormous that anyone who saw it would forget to breathe. It belonged to a powerful being—and somehow, it was beautiful.

The moment he faced that overwhelming presence, Jin Taekyung felt his senses sharpen with astonishing clarity.

Perhaps that was why he thought he met the gaze of two eyes like black obsidian, looking down imperiously on everyone below, blotting out even the moonlight.

Fwoooosh!

Space warped in an instant.

A terrifying pressure, too much for a mere bird to withstand, crushed the air.

No. It wasn't only Jin Taekyung.

Crack-crack-crack!

Countless fighter jets crumpled under the pressure.

As burning steel fell like a meteor shower, Jin Taekyung felt his consciousness fading.

At the same time, a sound he couldn't make sense of grew ever clearer in his ears.

Tick.

A streak of pure white light raced toward him from far away and swallowed him.

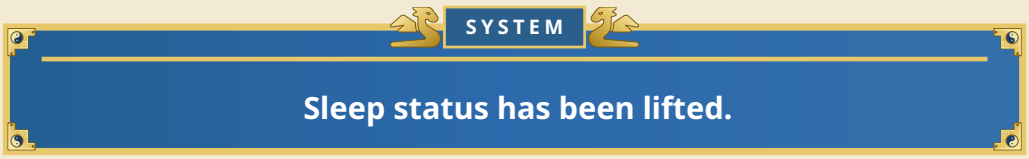
The human brain is much like iron.

Just as iron needs enough heat before it can be reshaped, a brain that has only just awakened needs a little time to start working.

But the moment I regained consciousness, I could sense everything around me more clearly than ever.

Even what had woken me from that deep sleep.

Ding.



A clear chime rang softly in my ears.

I lifted eyelids that felt lighter than down. A face filled my vision, looking down at me and half-obscuring an unfamiliar ceiling.

"A-Are you awake?"

When I met his eyes, trembling with emotion, a thought came to me.

How long I'd waited for this moment.

As I realized it, a gentle smile spread across my lips. The nightmare that had clung to me like glue just moments ago was already gone without a trace.

"Yes, Master."

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang paused at the effortless way I'd addressed him without a moment's hesitation. Then he answered in a choked voice.

Tried to.

Until a crowd of uninvited guests came rushing in with a clamor of heavy footsteps.

"Yes, my—"

Crash!

A deafening crash swallowed the rest of his words.

A huge man smashed the door to pieces and charged into the sickroom. Familiar faces streamed in behind him.

"He's awake!"

"He woke up!"

"He really woke up!"

"Wow! I've never seen anyone wake up after seven days!"

It took about one second.

That was how long the people staring at me with wide eyes, as if they couldn't believe what they were seeing, took to start screaming like mad and pounce on me.

"Aaah! Benefactor!"

"Pavilion Master!"

"Caaaaaptain!"

"…"

Yeah. It was nice.

But maybe I should've slept a little longer.

It took quite a while for everyone who'd rushed over at the news of my awakening—especially the members of the Fire Dragon Pavilion—to calm down.

"I really wasn't worried at all. I knew you'd wake up, Young Master Jin… I mean, Pavilion Master."

Ju Hwaran sniffled as she spoke. Beside her, Song Ilseom added calmly, "She cried her eyes out. Kept saying you might never wake up."

“I-I did not!”

“Yesterday. The day before. All seven days.”

Song Ilseom kept pelting the bright-red Ju Hwaran with facts. Then, in an instant, he changed his tune.

“Ah. I must have mistaken you for someone else.”

“You heard him, right? I didn’t cry at all.”

“…”

Ju Hwaran spoke with such confidence that I could only pretend I hadn’t seen the weighty money pouch she’d slipped Song Ilseom a moment ago.

Even without that cute little farce, voices were coming at me from every direction. I could barely catch my breath.

“I’m glad you’ve regained consciousness, Pavilion Master.”

Sama Pyo, whose ability to express emotion was about on par with an artificial intelligence’s, fell silent after that awkward remark. Taishan, whose emotions were closer to a wild animal’s, burst into tears.

“Taishan glad Pavilion Master awake. Worried so much, only ate three meals a day for seven days.”

“That’s incredible.”

I wasn’t being sarcastic. I was genuinely impressed.

It sounded insane at first, but considering Taishan’s usual appetite, that was practically a hunger strike.

The old man perched on Taishan’s shoulder as if it were his assigned seat sighed.

“Three meals a day *is* normal, you crazy bastard…”

“I cried so much, now hungry. Pavilion Master, I go eat.”

“Put me down before you go, you damned nuisance.”

Of course, Taishan paid him no mind.

He vanished like the wind. The old man clung tightly to the back of Taishan’s neck for dear life, his screams fading into the distance.

Someone else stepped into the space they left behind. He’d been waiting his turn, wrapped head to toe in bandages like a mummy.

“Captain…”

His voice was thick with tears.

I looked at him, moved.

“You…”

“Yes. It’s me. Your right arm. Your heart. Hyuk Mujin.”

“Right. You’re still alive, my little toe.”

“…”

“You look half-dead, but somehow you’re still breathing.”

Above the bandages, Hyuk Mujin's eyes, which had looked ready to overflow with tears, went cold.

"What? What's with that look?"

"…You know you're really too much, right?"

I frowned at the hurt in his voice.

"Too much? You're the one who was about to throw our promise away like it was worthless."

"What?"

"You forgot? The promise we made before the battle."

"Oh."

I'd told him plainly: if he was going to die, he had to do it in front of me. Then I'd make sure to avenge him.

But Hyuk Mujin apparently hadn't intended to keep that promise.

He'd fought recklessly, foolishly, even putting his own life on the line.

So there was only one thing I could say to him now.

"You've been through a lot."

Hyuk Mujin had been about to reply, but his eyes widened.

Or perhaps it was the look on my face and the quiet tone of my voice that stopped him.

I forced a smile and went on.

"And… thank you. For staying alive."

"…!"

"…!"

The air in the room quivered.

Everyone who'd been chattering a moment earlier fell silent as if on cue and looked at me.

They knew. Those few words weren't only for Hyuk Mujin. They were for all of them.

And this clumsy expression of emotion was the best I could manage right now.

"Well, that's all. I just felt like I had to say it."

Something stirred in my chest.

I smiled faintly, trying to hide my joy, my sorrow, and a swelling feeling I couldn't name.

The others seemed to feel much the same. Some smiled back. Some cried quietly. Others watched them without a word.

The ones who'd been through all this long ago were the ones who watched. They hadn't grown used to it. They'd grown numb.

"Come to think of it, I have something urgent to take care of."

Jeok Cheongang rose, muttering as if to himself.

“Might take about half a *shichen*[3886].”

With that, he left the sickroom. Two others who had appeared at the door at some point, watching us quietly, went with him.

Sometimes, a thought occurs to me.

Sword Saint Mae Jonghak, about to turn away with the Slaughter Saint, moved his lips.

Perhaps being able to laugh when you can, and cry when you want to, is a great blessing.

The old men had walked that road before. Now the young were walking it.

That was why they were giving us some space, if only for a little while.

So we could feel everything this moment held, knowing it might be our last. So we could accept both the joy of surviving and meeting again and the grief for those who had left us, then continue on our way.

“Get some rest. I’ll be back.”

I nodded quietly.

By the time they returned and our conversation was over, the whole world had sunk into darkness.

Just like the nightmare I’d had before waking.

[3886] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of roughly two hours; half a *shichen* is about one hour.

Chapter 1139

As I listened to the account unfold, I found myself holding my breath again and again.

The Central Plains Murim—or rather, the whole realm—was coming together.

I'd known it was all but inevitable. Still, hearing it from the current Alliance Leader himself gave the news a different weight.

The sheer numbers had something to do with that, too.

A hundred thousand.

No fewer than a hundred thousand elite Imperial Guards were racing north along the Yellow River, swift as shafts of light.

Under the command of none other than the Son of Heaven.

Looks like that old man managed to stay alive after all.

I suddenly remembered the last time I'd seen the Son of Heaven.

His aged face belied his youth, and his complexion had been as pale as a sheet. The ruler of a vast continent had been on the brink of death. Before long, he surely would have died.

If not for the worn-out old book I'd given him as a parting gift.

White Illusion Jiangshi Art.

A secret art of the Maoshan Sect—and demonic martial arts that defied all common sense.

The more one practiced it, the more one became a jiangshi. It was no better than a poisoned Holy Grail, but the Son of Heaven seemed to have drunk from it willingly.

A Holy Grail was still a Holy Grail, after all.

Even in an age when the Three Bonds and Five Relationships[3887] were alive and well, they meant nothing if you couldn't breathe.

Especially when he had one blood relative who would have to shoulder all his burdens.

And the Son of Heaven wasn't the only one with someone to protect.

"The Yangtze and the Yellow River are packed from bank to bank. Everyone's coming here."

Mae Jonghak hadn't exaggerated when he said "everyone."

The hundred thousand Imperial Guards led by the Son of Heaven were only part of the enormous force gathering.

From the great Murim sects to reclusive masters hidden deep in the mountains, all the way down to Third Rate swordsmen.

[3887] The Three Bonds and Five Relationships are Confucian principles governing duties between rulers and subjects, parents and children, spouses, elders and juniors, and friends.

Once the blade at their throats—the Moving Formation—had been broken, they all smashed through the fence and poured out.

Countless ships covered the rivers, while galloping hooves shook the earth.

All for one goal.

To cool the heat raging in their hearts like molten lava.

“The sacrifices made by you and so many others are what made them rise up.”

Some who had cowered in fear must have felt ashamed. Others must have blamed themselves for not being there to fight alongside us.

Of course, people weren’t as righteous as they liked to think. Some might have taken up arms simply to make a name for themselves.

But their reasons didn’t matter.

At least now, we could come together as one.

That was why I could understand the position the Alliance Leader before me had been in.

“You don’t have to apologize.”

At my sudden words, Mae Jonghak, whose face had been stern the entire time, bit his lip.

“…My friend.”

“To be honest, yes. There were times when I thought we’d been abandoned.”

To catch a big fish, you needed bait.

This time, Xining had been the bait.

The kind so tempting that Dark Heaven couldn’t help but bite.

But the Murim Alliance hadn’t thought of us as mere bait or pawns to be discarded.

They’d drawn up an elaborate plan in the strictest secrecy. Though they’d been a step too late, they’d sent powerful reinforcements—and even uprooted the last lingering threat the Blood Lord had left behind.

“So please, don’t apologize.”

I met Mae Jonghak’s wavering gaze and added quietly,

“If only for the sake of those who are gone.”

“…!”

“They chose their path. They’d already accepted that they might die, and they fought with courage to match. More bravely than anyone.”

Mae Jonghak had no reason to apologize.

No. If he did, it would be no different from insulting the dead.

Jeong Hogun and a thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards. Countless martial artists and government troops. Even the common folk who’d taken up rusty axes and sickles to hold back the invaders.

Every one of them had been a hero.

So had those who, like Mae Jonghak before me, had struggled behind the scenes for this great victory.

That left us with only one goal.

"We have to repay this blood debt many times over. All of us, together."

Everyone here knew who we had to collect that debt from. So did the whole realm.

The Lord of Heaven.

Or—

Asmodeus.

The supreme demon. The king of the Demon Realm.

The name of the being that had finally intruded into reality lingered on my tongue like a bitter poison.

And with it, the name of someone else bound to him.

Cheon Taemin.

No.

The Martial God.

Time flew by.

One day, thick snow fell as though it were the middle of winter. On another, wind and rain raged as if they meant to swallow the whole world.

Then, three days after I regained consciousness, a sight I'd never seen before appeared beyond the heat haze rising in the blazing sun.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

The war drums of Xining City, silent for ten days, sounded their deep call. But not a trace of fear showed on the faces of the people crowding the walls.

Everyone in Xining simply watched, their hearts swelling.

East, west, south, and north.

Across winding hills and vast plains, and along the Yellow River, a wave of countless banners surged toward us.

"The enemy! The enemy's here!"

"…"

Take that back about everyone.

Wherever you go, there's always some lunatic who can't read the room.

"Do you not hear me? Prepare for battle at once!"

Jeok Cheongang watched the Great Sir hopping up and down, then turned to me.

"Er, would you happen to…"

I felt his gaze on my cheek and cut him off before he could finish.

"No."

“I haven’t said anything yet.”

“You were about to ask if you could kill him.”

“Hmm.”

“You can’t break his arms and legs, either.”

“Ah.”

“Just leave him alone. Best to leave a madman be. Besides, he’s a useful madman.”

“What good is he in battle if every time he opens his mouth, I feel like I’m about to suffer qi deviation?”

Honestly, I couldn’t disagree.

They said he’d darted all over the battlefield like Hong Gil-dong,[3888] saving a great many of our people. But after the battle, he’d become plain old Gil-dung.

A pile of shit planted in the middle of the road, with everyone edging around it.

The one saving grace was that even ordinary people now knew the Great Sir wasn’t just any lunatic.

“That old man’s at it again…”

“Whew, I thought something serious had happened. When he shouted ‘enemy,‘ I nearly had a heart attack.”

He was so well-known that even the people who’d jumped at the shout calmed down as soon as they saw him.

“But what happened to that Great Hero? He looked perfectly fine when he fought those Dark Heaven bastards.”

“Who knows? Maybe he fell off a cliff looking for a fortuitous encounter.”

“…”

I was listening to these commoners, who knew a suspicious amount about martial-arts clichés, when—

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

The pounding of hooves shook the earth, and an enormous cheer erupted, swallowing up the scattered murmurs in an instant.

“Waaah!”

At that moment, a wind blew in from far away. The banners caught it and billowed above the feverish crowd.

The fifteen pillars that upheld the realm’s Murim.

The Nine Sects and One Gang. The Five Great Families.

The overlords of the various provinces, the large and small Murim sects that followed them—and a name unfamiliar to some: Nanman Beast Palace.

Among all those names fluttering fiercely toward the sky, two banners rose higher and larger than the rest.

[3888] Hong Gil-dong is the outlaw hero of a classic Korean novel, associated with appearing here and there in a flash.

“The Murim Alliance…!”

The martial artists of Xining were moved at the sight of the banner that represented them. The government troops and commoners, meanwhile, stared wide-eyed at the presence of a man they’d thought they would never meet in their lives.

“T-The Emperor!”

“So the rumors that he’d lead a personal expedition were true!”

The brilliant golden dragon embroidered on his banner shone through even the thick heat haze. At the sight of it, people dropped to their knees and bowed low.

To the ruler of the Great Nation.

No, to the ruler of Great Ming—their father.

“What an uproar. A real uproar.”

Jeok Cheongang was right. The whole place had gone wild.

Some slammed their heads against the wall until they bled. Others wailed as though they were about to faint.

They weren’t even close enough to see his face yet, and this was how they were acting.

At this rate, you could call him North Korea’s three ruling Kims[3889]—or an unlucky Lord of Heaven—and no one could argue.

“Come to think of it, he’s only one character away from the Lord of Heaven.”

Jeok Cheongang heard me mutter and spoke in a slightly uneasy voice.

“Keep your voice down. There are plenty of ears around.”

“That’s why I kept it down.”

“Lower.”

“Come on, this is fine. Since when have we worried about stuff like this?”

“No, you’re not wrong, but still, look around…”

“What did I do? You’ve always taught me, Master, to speak my mind—even if I’m dragged before Yama.”

“…!”

“What?”

Jeok Cheongang silently twitched his nose for a moment, then turned away.

Watching the procession rapidly draw nearer, he muttered as though to himself.

To himself, mind you.

“That sounds nice.”

“Huh?”

“But the more I hear it, the more I think ‘Master’ sounds a bit too stiff…”

“Are you talking to me?”

[3889] Kim Il-sung, Kim Jong-il, and Kim Jong-un are three successive rulers of North Korea.

“Ah, what a nice day. A beautiful day, and my one and only disciple is so damn clueless…”

“Yeah. Really beautiful out.”

“…”

“What?”

Maybe I should stop teasing him before he got annoyed.

His nostrils were flaring now too, and I was just about to let out the snicker I’d been holding back when—

Grrrrumble.

With a heavy rumble, the bridge lowered across the moat.

At the same time, a dazzlingly white horse stepped forward.

Beneath the people’s cheers, joy and tears mingled together.

“Long live the Emperor! Long live Great Ming!”

The Son of Heaven.

At last, he had arrived.

The ruler of the continent, who could drive fans and haters—or rather, the common people—mad just by showing up.

But unlike some miserable bastard lurking beyond the desert, this ersatz Lord of Heaven was on our side. That was what mattered.

His baby brother, whom he doted on, was the president of my fan club, and the entire Imperial House owed me a very big debt.

“It’s been a long time, Marquis of Shangshan Jin Taekyung.”

He crossed the city gates and entered Xining at last. I stood there with my back impudently straight, and he smiled gently at me.

“No, I suppose I should call you Prince Shangshan now.”

“…?”

Mom. I’m a king now.

Chapter 1140

Long before the countless government and Murim forces appeared beneath hundreds of flying banners, the people of Xining City were already bursting with excitement at the news of reinforcements.

“I never thought I’d live to see a sight like this.”

The imperial court and the Murim Alliance, united.

That alone was unprecedented in the history of the continent. And the people gathered under those banners were just as extraordinary.

“T-The Nine Sects and One Gang, and the Five Great Families, too? All of them?”

“That’s right. They’ve even rooted out every last one of those Dark Heaven bastards’ dark arts planted in the Central Plains. What is there to fear now?”

“I-I heard the Silver Flash Spear and the Taebaek Divine Elder have joined them, too.”

“Hold on. The Silver Flash Spear, sure—but wasn’t that old Taebaek Divine Elder a dark-path figure?”

“…I’m a dark-path figure, too.”

“Oh, right. I forgot. You’re with the Yangtze River Channel League.”

“Just laugh it off. Don’t ruin the mood.”

Leaders of renowned sects. Great Heroes who had roamed the realm alone. Even reclusive masters who had supposedly died long ago.

The orthodox martial artists weren’t the only ones unable to hide their excitement. Even dark-path martial artists, who reached for their weapons at the slightest provocation, felt it this time.

They had already fought alongside the legends known as the Three Saints, but wasn’t this true unity?

Even during the terrible Great Faction War, the forces of the entire Murim had never come together in one place like this.

The government troops and commoners were trembling with excitement, too, each for their own reasons.

The Son of Heaven.

A descendant of the dragon.

The father and ruler of all people, sent by Heaven to this land.

They could scarcely believe their ears when they heard that the man said to be impossible to see even if you lived in the Imperial Capital was personally leading a great army here. Before long, they learned it was true.

The Son of Heaven’s lofty authority and grace, known to them only through rumor.

And—

“It’s been a long time, Marquis of Shangshan Jin Taekyung.”

Even his connection to one particular person.

But the Son of Heaven's next words were something no one there could have predicted.

"No, I suppose I should call you Prince Shangshan now."

"…!"

"…!"

The sudden sense that the air around them had crackled wasn't one person's imagination.

Martial artists, government troops, commoners.

For a moment, they all wondered if they'd heard the same thing wrong. Then they looked at one another's wide eyes and understood.

They hadn't misheard. Not at all.

The Son of Heaven had just declared it.

No—proclaimed it.

He would make that young man, with not a single drop of noble dragon's blood in his veins, a king.

A king of another surname, a title lost to history for hundreds of years, had just been created anew right here.

And amid the unprecedented scene that had frozen everyone in place, Jin Taekyung—who, for some reason, was staring into empty space—suddenly spoke.

"Wow. The EXP for that achievement is insane."

"…?"

"…?"

What the hell was he talking about?

Having thrown everyone into confusion with words no one could understand, Jin Taekyung looked straight at the Son of Heaven and continued.

"Your Majesty."

His expression was utterly serious.

"Since you're handing them out anyway, could you go big and give me a few more royal titles?"

The Son of Heaven burst out laughing. The people, stunned for a moment, all had the same thought.

He really was a complete madman.

But the madman who'd just become a king wasn't done yet.

Afterward, people had to keep asking themselves, and reminding themselves, what they knew about the man named Jin Taekyung.

What had they heard in all those rumors about him?

Before long, they were able to confirm it with their own eyes and ears.

“Is Prince Shangshan not enough? It was also the title held by my younger brother, so it carries considerable significance.”

“Oh, it’s plenty. It’s great. I was just wondering if I could get one more. Hehe.”

Jin Taekyung was wheedling another royal title out of the Emperor as if he were asking for extra broth with his noodles. Everyone held their breath.

Some even thought the Son of Heaven, known for being iron-blooded, would punish Jin Taekyung on the spot.

For a very brief moment.

“If you tell me why, I see no reason to refuse.”

Huh?

“Um. It’s a little awkward to explain in detail. I’m just giving it a try.”

Why?

“Hm. You must have your reasons. Then you may also take the title of Prince of Ye in Hebei.”

What?

“Thank you—hm.”

“What is it?”

“Nothing. I’ll pass on Prince of Ye. Ah, I guess you can’t have duplicates.”

“I don’t know what you mean, but do as you please.”

…Seriously, what was going on?

Everyone who’d watched the whole exchange was half out of their minds.

Even after the Son of Heaven had traded a few more words and laughs with Jin Taekyung and headed toward the Inner City with the Imperial Guards, the shock didn’t fade.

Instead, a different kind of shock awaited them.

Thud-thud-thud-thud!

A flood of men and horses poured through the wide-open city gates beneath countless banners bearing the emblems of the great sects.

At the sight of the figures emerging with imposing auras and gleaming eyes, the people cried out in amazement. Then a familiar feeling struck them.

Along with the same shock as before.

“Benefactor Jin, do you remember me?”

“Daoist Jin. You’ve been through so much.”

“Long time no see. Are you hurt?”

Monks and Daoists from the Nine Sects and One Gang, along with renowned masters from the Five Great Families.

As if they'd planned it, they gathered around Jin Taekyung. He greeted the towering figures of the realm's Murim as if there were nothing unusual about it.

"How could I forget Master Unnamed? But you've gotten even more muscular since I last saw you… Wow."

Unnamed, the sole Disciple of Dharma King Hong Dao, and the man who had sworn not to take the seat of Abbot of Shaolin until Dark Heaven was rooted out.

"Heavenly Sword True Person, you came, too. Oh, Cheongpung? He was over there, but now he's gone. By the way, did your Disciples come with you?"

The Heavenly Sword True Person, Sect Leader of Huashan in his own right, quite apart from being Sword Saint Mae Jonghak's Disciple.

And—

"You haven't changed a bit, Daoist Jin."

"We owe you a great debt for what happened in Sichuan. If it hadn't been for you…"

"That reminds me of what happened in Hubei."

Other Sect Leaders, Family Heads, and heads of sects.

Even an Elder of a great sect could barely get a foot in. Anyone below that rank couldn't get close enough to greet Jin Taekyung.

There simply wasn't room.

Jin Taekyung stood surrounded by the leaders of the great sects—including Emei, Wudang, and the Beggars' Sect. It was enough to make people doubt their eyes.

The arrival of the Sichuan Tang Clan's Family Head, whose foul temper everyone knew about, and the Palace Lord of the Nanman Beast Palace, whom they'd only heard of in rumors, poured oil on the fire.

"I've come to pay my respects to the Tang Family's Benefactor. Please forgive me for being unavoidably late."

Tang Sadok, the Myriad-Poison Asura, was said to prefer a drop of poison to a word of conversation. Yet he clasped his hands in a deeply respectful salute.

"Damn it. I thought they'd come to Sichuan, too… But I was held up by those bastards. Even feeding them to that tiger wouldn't have satisfied me. I have no excuse."

Yayul Cheok, the burly man wrapped in tiger hide, even lowered his head and watched Jin Taekyung's face for a reaction.

As if he were guilty of something.

"…Was he really that important?"

At the words someone muttered, those who had watched the whole scene felt a shiver they couldn't explain.

Who were these people?

Titans who represented not just their own provinces, but the Murim of the entire realm.

Even if Jin Taekyung was the Fire King's Disciple, the gulf between him and those people should have been vast—in age and in the forces they commanded.

But today, they finally understood.

Or rather, they saw and felt what they'd only vaguely suspected until now.

Just how great Jin Taekyung's standing was in this world.

And at the same time, they suddenly sensed something else.

The age of the stars and kings was drawing to a close.

That young Divine Dragon, coiled among countless towering trees, was the hero who would swallow the dark clouds of Dark Heaven and soar into the boundless sky.

At last—

A new age was beckoning to the realm.

Getting away from the gathering hadn't been easy.

Everyone who'd met me before wanted to greet me, and so did people who'd never met me.

"Great Hero Jin!"

"Oh, yes. Nice to meet you."

"Please accept a drink from me! I'll count it the honor of a lifetime!"

"I think I've heard that about fifty times already… But sure, hand it over."

With joy overflowing everywhere, maybe it was only natural that the cups overflowed, too.

I'd clasped hands in salute hundreds of times and accepted dozens of drinks.

Xining City had long since become one enormous banquet hall. It took a long time before I could finally make my way out.

"Mother, our youngest is a kiiiing now. Sniff, sob."

"Mother Goddess Heaven! Unbeliever Hell! The great Earth Mother Goddess will punish that fucking Lord of Heaven!"

"Long live the Emperor! I'll cross the desert right now and smash those rebels' heads in…!"

"…"

My head was spinning.

Jin Wikyung had dropped his stern-and-serious act and started crying as soon as he got drunk. The Earth Mother Goddess's fanatics—by now, she was practically Nanman's One God—were shouting their slogans.

Leaving behind the cries of Great Ming's subjects, all fired up with loyalty, I walked off alone.

I kept going until all the noise had faded away.

Past the East Gate, as far as the river beyond the reach of Xining City's lights, which filled every street.

And there, I came face-to-face with someone I hadn't seen in the past three days.

No—someone I'd deliberately avoided seeking out while I sorted through the thoughts tangled in my head.

Shhk.

Wet sand gave softly beneath my slow step.

Standing beside the Bow Saint, I watched the rippling river in silence.

For a long, long time afterward.

Chapter 1141

The Bow Saint's lips, long pressed shut, finally parted as even the music drifting from beyond the distant city walls began to fade.

"It sounds lovely."

I wasn't sure what she meant—the river flowing past us, or the laughter carried on the breeze.

I could only answer with a quiet nod.

"After a hard-fought battle ended in victory, there was always a feast like that. People would laugh and chatter until dawn, passing cups of wine back and forth without pause."

The Bow Saint's soft voice carried memories she'd held onto for a long time.

And in the scene slowly taking shape before my eyes, she must have been just as alone, just as apart from everyone, as she was today.

"They must have wanted to laugh, even if only for a little while. They needed days like that to take even one more step forward."

Enough time had passed for the mountains and rivers to change hands several times over, but the human heart remained the same.

Then and now, those who survived gathered together and raised their cups.

One for the joy of victory. One to honor their fallen comrades.

And one more for the time they had left, which might be their last.

That was why this was both a feast and a memorial rite.

"But I could never join them."

I'd been staring silently at the river. Only then did I part my lips.

"Why not?"

"The weight pressing down on my body and mind was too much to bear. I was so worried about what lay ahead that I couldn't even let myself feel those fleeting emotions."

For the first time, she took her gaze off the river and looked at me, her eyes as composed as ever.

"And whenever that happened, someone would come to me without a word and stay by my side."

"…!"

My fingertips trembled before I could stop them.

I knew.

I knew who the Bow Saint was talking about.

What I hadn't guessed was that she'd also figured out why I'd come to see her.

"So, what do you want to hear?"

Under the Bow Saint's gaze, which seemed to see straight through me, I took a moment to steady my breathing.

Then I answered.

"The Martial God. I want to know everything about him."

No.

I needed to know now. I had to.

Several decades ago, there was a man.

His sect, his face, even his name—none of them were properly known.

But the first time he appeared in history, everyone under Heaven learned of his existence.

"He was like… a divine man who had descended from the heavens."

In the early days of the Great Faction War, the Demonic Cult drenched Kunlun Mountain in blood and fired the first shot of the war. As the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples bore down like a giant wave, the Central Plains Murim fell into utter chaos.

Until *he* appeared.

"Three Supreme Peak fiends, and five thousand Demonic Cultists. After suffering a crushing defeat in its first battle, the Kongtong Sect tried to retreat to Shaanxi at once, but the enemy soon caught up. The reinforcements summoned in haste couldn't arrive as quickly as the Demonic Cult."

And on that day—

An unknown man stood in the pursuers' path, and a new sky opened.

"Before even half a day had passed, every enemy had been killed or captured. It was hard to believe one person had done it all."

But the Huashan reinforcements, arriving late, saw everything with their own eyes.

Amid a battlefield that looked as though a storm had swept through it, a man stood alone among countless corpses.

They were all stunned. They shuddered with awe.

One of them must have felt something beyond awe: the man leading the reinforcements, the head of that generation's Plum Blossom Swordsmen, who at barely thirty was revered as the Number One Sword Under Heaven.

"Mae Jonghak immediately spread the news throughout the realm. Before long, everyone knew: there was another supreme being who would stand against the Heavenly Demon and protect the Central Plains."

And so the Martial God was born.

The years of war that followed, lasting more than a decade, became the legend he wrote.

Victory, and more victory.

There were countless defeats and moments of despair, too. But there was also glory and praise, as hot and dazzling as the sun.

He brought the Nine Sects and One Gang and the Five Great Families, long divided and reunited by turns, together beneath the banner of the Murim Alliance. He sought no personal gain, pursuing only benevolence and righteousness.

A great hero of his age, held in awe by all.

“I watched it all from close by. Again and again, I marveled at his achievements, too great to put into words. There were those who dared to envy, resent, and doubt him, but before long, even they came to admire the Martial God deeply.”

Who under Heaven could look straight at the sun?

And without the sun, how could anyone live in this world?

The Martial God was the heavens—and the sun itself.

No matter how many jiazi[3890] of internal energy one had accumulated, no matter how high one’s martial prowess, no one dared look straight at him.

Afraid of being blinded, they could only bow their heads in the end.

And the Martial God proved himself.

He defeated a supreme being unlike any other in the thousand-year history of the Demonic Path, then disappeared without a trace not long afterward.

Glory. Honor. History.

Even this vast realm of Murim.

The Martial God cast aside everything he had built without a trace of attachment and left.

“And that was when the legend finally became a myth.”

The Bow Saint raised her head and looked up at the sky.

In the pitch-black night, stars glittered, echoing her title. But beside the vast heavens above, they were no more than tiny lights.

“Those who lived in the same era as me know. The Martial God was truly a miraculous being. No one under Heaven could ever accomplish what he did.”

When her long story ended, silence settled. I’d been looking at her without a word when I suddenly parted my lips.

“Is that all?”

The Bow Saint’s gaze slid slowly down from the sky to me.

“What do you mean?”

“I already told you. I want to know everything about him.”

[3890] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

"…Why would you think that isn't everything?"

Her answer came a fraction too late.

For an instant, I thought her eyes had wavered ever so slightly. Was that just my imagination, or had I mistaken the river reflected in them for a flicker in her gaze?

I kept the question to myself and spoke again.

"I expected a somewhat different story. Of the people I know, you spent the longest time with the Martial God. And you were the one who received his letter."

"How could I tell you everything about more than a decade in so short a time? Besides, plenty of people remember what he did. Staying a little closer to him would hardly make my account different."

Despite that fleeting hint of agitation, her voice was as calm as ever.

"The same goes for the letter. In keeping with his final wish, I spent many years searching for the 'chosen one.' That is why we stand here together now."

That was true. I knew it, too.

The Bow Saint had spent decades wandering the realm. Her own life bore out her words.

And I knew that the woman before me had walked a difficult path as a chivalrous warrior—one I wasn't qualified to judge.

But to my mind, her answer was both entirely true and incomplete.

She's definitely hiding something.

This wasn't a passing guess. Instinct and cold reason had brought me to the same conclusion.

We hadn't known each other long, but we'd faced life and death together many times. Even so, the Bow Saint had repeatedly kept herself apart from the rest of us.

And most importantly—

That battle ten days ago.

I remembered what the Slaughter Saint had cautiously told me the night before, when he came to see me alone.

The Bow Saint's inexplicable words and actions that day.

Putting it all together, she'd been closer to a bystander than anything else.

At least when it came to whether I lived or died.

What if our positions had been reversed?

I'd already turned the question over in my mind several times. It didn't even need thinking through.

I would have done everything I could to save the Bow Saint.

Whether I'd moved on instinct or reason.

But she hadn't.

On the day of the great battle surrounding Xining, she'd told the Slaughter Saint, who wanted to save me, that if Jin Taekyung died that day, then it was fate.

Of course, she wasn't wrong.

With countless people dying on every side, how could one life matter more than another?

But why had the Bow Saint, who'd spent decades searching for the "chosen one" on the strength of an old letter supposedly left by the Martial God, been so indifferent to my death?

Could it be…

Could she have…

No. The Martial God…

As I swallowed a breath—

Splash!

A surge of river water rushed up and touched my toes.

Cold seeped into my leather shoes. Snapped out of my thoughts, I instinctively stepped back.

Then I met a pair of eyes watching me intently.

"There's one last thing I'd like to ask."

She gave a small nod, and I continued, my voice trembling now.

"Why… did the Martial God want to find me?"

The Bow Saint answered at once.

"For the sake of the realm. That's all."

Her eyes shone clearly, and her voice was firm.

I could feel it instinctively.

This was the truth.

Not a trace of a lie or ill will.

And for now, that was enough.

For the sake of the realm.

I swallowed those few words as they kept ringing in my ears, then bowed my head to the Bow Saint.

"Thank you."

"Was that enough of an answer?"

"To some extent, yes."

"I'm surprised. I thought you'd want to know more about him."

"I'd be lying if I said I wasn't disappointed, but what you've told me has already helped a great deal."

I wasn't just saying what she wanted to hear. I wasn't lying.

Hearing about the beginning and end of the being called the Martial God had finally made me certain of the identity of another person like him—one who had existed beneath a different sky.

Chapter 1142

Though the hour of the Rabbit[3891] had begun, the lights of Xining City showed no sign of going out.

People wept and laughed, passing cups of wine back and forth without end as they gave themselves over to drink.

No—they could hardly do otherwise.

Wine helped them forget what they felt. They could blame the tears they'd shed without realizing it on the drink, and pretend not to notice someone weeping for a loved one they'd lost.

But one man was different. Seated on the roof of the tallest pavilion along the main road, he stared silently down at the streets below.

"What are you doing up here?"

At the unexpected voice behind him, the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, answered gruffly.

"Just thinking."

"Thinking?"

"What, do I look like a man who never thinks?"

"Of course not. Your lie was just painfully obvious."

The uninvited guest—the Slaughter Saint—plopped down beside him without permission and gave a quiet laugh.

"Why not be a little honest for once? You could admit you haven't touched a drop of wine because you're waiting for your one and only Disciple."

"…"

"You worry too much. Especially for a Master with the finest Disciple under Heaven."

At that, Jeok Cheongang's brows, which had been wriggling like a caterpillar, arched gently.

"Hm. The boy is pretty good."

"Pretty good? Who else has achieved so much at his age, in all of history?"

"Now, now. He was just lucky. He's still a long way from meeting my expectations."

"…Then why are you grinning like an idiot?"

"You must be drunk. You're imagining things."

Jeok Cheongang's mouth twitched as if he were having a spasm. The Slaughter Saint shook his head.

"Anyway, don't worry for nothing. He must have had a lot to discuss with the Bow Saint."

[3891] The hour of the Rabbit is a traditional time period from approximately 5 to 7 a.m.

“Oh, he went to see the Bow Saint? I had no idea.”

It was true.

Of course, Jeok Cheongang had been waiting for more than two shichen,[3892] ever since Jin Taekyung had quietly slipped away. But anyway, he had no idea.

“Would you stop pretending? Not even a toddler would believe your lies.”

Even with his thoughts completely exposed, Jeok Cheongang held on to his usual confidence.

“I’m serious. Besides, I’m not even sure who this Bow Saint is.”

“…Enough. Are you going to pretend to be senile just to tell one lie?”

“A martial artist must be willing to give up flesh to take bone.”

“It’s the other way around in this case.”

“If I give up bone and take flesh, I still come out ahead. My bones are strong.”

“Now you’re talking nonsense like Jin Taekyung. When it comes to things like this, Master and Disciple really are…”

The Slaughter Saint sighed softly and turned away.

He’d come looking because neither Master nor Disciple was anywhere to be seen. Somehow, everyone who bore the name of the Fire Gate Clan, old or young, gave him a headache.

That aside, there was something he wanted to say to Jeok Cheongang.

“This might be presumptuous, but may I say something?”

“Absolutely not.”

Ignoring the gruff reply, the Slaughter Saint continued.

“Don’t blame yourself so much.”

“What?”

“It wasn’t your fault the boy nearly died ten days ago. Nor was it your fault the Dharma King and the Thunderbolt Saber King died.”

“…”

“If you’re guilty of anything, blame yourself for having a Disciple who’s too outstanding. As for the other two, tear the Lord of Heaven to pieces for them.”

The Slaughter Saint was about to leave Jeok Cheongang to his silence when Jeok spoke.

“Do you have any wine?”

“Of course.”

“Leave it here.”

“Ask a little more politely, and I might consider it.”

“Fine. But first, shall we get our ages straight?”

“Come on. That’s harsh, when we’re both getting old.”

[3892] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

With a quiet laugh, the Slaughter Saint tossed the gourd at his waist over his shoulder and left. Alone again, Jeok Cheongang slowly tipped the wine-filled gourd toward the ground, looking out in the direction of the Central Plains thousands of *li*[3893] away.

"You damned monk. And you, Peng. You'll have to make do with this for now. I'll hold a proper memorial for you in Xinjiang."

Then Jeok Cheongang spotted the East Gate beginning to open beneath the hazy moonlight and smiled.

"With my outstanding Disciple."

Whoosh.

As he kicked off the roof and vanished, something at his neck glinted.

Leaving the Bow Saint behind, I walked alone through Xining City's dark, winding alleys.

The main road still blazed with colorful lights and rang with countless voices, but only one person occupied my thoughts.

The Martial God.

This wasn't the first time I'd heard about him.

I'd heard more than enough, in fact.

The Martial God's deeds, beginning as legend and ending as myth, had long since become sacred and untouchable. Though their memories differed somewhat, every martial artist I'd met had praised him, regardless of standing.

It was all too familiar.

Cheon Taemin.

Known as Slayer. Or Sky, a name taken from his surname.

The path he'd walked as humanity's savior and an unparalleled great hero was astonishingly similar to the Martial God's. So similar that, at some point, it had gone beyond déjà vu and started sending a chill down my spine.

At first, I thought they were just alike.

It hadn't seemed all that strange. History had seen heroes with great missions appear from time to time and bring an age of chaos to an end. Cheon Taemin and the Martial God had seemed like two such heroes to me.

Yeah. That was what I'd thought.

Until, a few months ago, I heard something unbelievable from one person.

"So it was you. You're the 'chosen one.'"

The Bow Saint.

[3893] This uses the Chinese *li*: one *li* is approximately 500 m (0.311 mi).

She'd been hiding in the imperial court under a false identity, searching for me for a long time.

No—for the Player hidden behind the title of "chosen one."

"Blazing Flame Divine Dragon Jin Taekyung. The moment I saw you rise again after suffering what should have been a mortal wound, I finally knew who the chosen one he spoke of was."

It was as vivid as if it had happened yesterday. The shock of that day had felt like a bolt of lightning striking the top of my head.

That was when I started to suspect who the Martial God really was.

But finding an answer hadn't been easy.

After that day, the Bow Saint kept her lips firmly shut. And I'd had no time to spare while dealing with the fires erupting across the realm.

Besides, though the answer seemed obvious at first glance, one problem stood in my way—a problem I couldn't explain.

If Cheon Taemin and the Martial God are the same person… how did I come to Murim?

The capsule.

That beat-up hunk of junk had appeared before me out of nowhere one day. It was a passage connecting the modern world and Murim, and the thin *User Manual* that came with it contained all kinds of information.

Manufacturer. Date of manufacture. Precautions.

And finally, Main Features.

> A capsule customized for just one person! Once a user is registered, the capsule is permanently bound to them until their death.

Those two lines at the very top of the Main Features section were enough to send me into an endless maze.

After all, I was one of the few people who'd seen Cheon Taemin alive with my own eyes. Granted, he was practically in a vegetative state, but there was no doubt he was still breathing.

That was why I couldn't explain it.

If Cheon Taemin really had been a Player who owned the capsule before me, and if he was the Martial God, how could I have gained ownership of it?

But now it was time to reach some kind of conclusion to this old question.

I decided to untangle my thoughts by changing how I approached it. The method was simple.

Which is more likely: that they're the same person, or that they're two different people?

I'd asked myself that question over and over, even after regaining consciousness. And I'd arrived at an answer long ago.

First: Cheon Taemin and the Martial God are the same person.

And second—

The System may have recognized Cheon Taemin's unconscious state as a form of death.

The second part was still only a guess. But after all the time I'd spent thinking about it, this was the closest I could get to an answer.

There's one more thing that bothers me: the time ratio…

The difference in time between the Great Cataclysm in the modern world and the Great Faction War in Murim was roughly twofold. But that fell far short of the time ratio the System had given me. That generous ratio was one of the biggest reasons I'd been able to grow so quickly.

There must be something else I haven't figured out yet.

The System was meticulous. It could seem impossibly capricious at times, but it operated by set rules, and there was a reason for everything it did.

So it wouldn't be strange if there were specific conditions or secrets it didn't reveal unless a Player figured them out for himself. The System had always worked that way, and it probably always would.

And among all the thoughts tangled in my head like a skein of thread, only one presence remained.

"…Who in the world is that old man?"

The Helper.

This was the second time I'd met him face-to-face.

When I first set foot in Murim, he'd appeared as part of the System and taught me to circulate my qi. This time, he'd saved my life.

If he hadn't guided me to a higher level of enlightenment, I'd be a cold corpse by now, buried in Xining City's graveyard.

Or in an urn Jeok Cheongang had picked out himself.

Anyway, what mattered was that he wasn't merely part of the System. He was something special.

"Definitely different from what I thought I knew."

My mutter echoed through the dark alley.

"What nonsense are you talking about now?"

The voice sounded gruff at first, but there was an unmistakable warmth beneath it.

When Jeok Cheongang suddenly appeared, I started to smile.

I would have, if I hadn't seen what hung around his neck.

"…!"

My eyes flew wide. Reflected in them was a pocket watch glinting in the hazy moonlight.

Chapter 1143

It took three steps to get my stalled brain back up and running.

First, roughly thirty seconds of silence.

Second, someone's muffled shout, as if it were echoing from deep underwater.

And finally, the grand third step.

Whoosh!

A figure strode closer, and a palm came flying at me with a sharp whistle.

Smack!

Light flashed before my eyes.

As my dulled senses returned, the breath I'd unknowingly been holding burst out of me in a gasp.

"…A-are you back with us?"

I could barely answer. All I managed was a blink.

Jeok Cheongang had come right up to me, staring with a look that mingled confusion and concern.

And peeking out from the gap in his robe, as if it were a third eye, was an object glaring right back at me.

"T-that. That thing."

"What?"

"No, I mean, uh…"

So much for my brain being back up and running.

My tongue had gone stiff. I couldn't get the words out, like Mute Samryong[3894]. It wasn't until I saw my Master raising his hand again—for his Disciple's sake, naturally—that I finally came to my senses.

"W-wait!"

Smack!

Ah, the boundless grace of a master. My eardrum was ringing with it.

"…I said wait."

Jeok Cheongang flinched at the betrayal in my eyes.

"I thought you were on the verge of qi deviation…"

"Wouldn't you have to be more careful if I really were having qi deviation?"

"You're fine if you're only on the verge. Ever heard of fighting fire with fire?"

I wasn't sure that was the right expression for this situation, but the real issue was something else.

The culprit who'd made Jeok Cheongang suspect I was on the verge of qi deviation was still swaying before my eyes.

[3894] An allusion to Na Dohyang's Korean short story *Mute Samryong*.

As if trying to hypnotize me.

“By the way… where did you get that?”

Even as I asked, I felt uneasy.

If that unexpected object hanging around Jeok Cheongang’s neck really was the one I knew, how was I supposed to make sense of it?

His answer only made my heart sink further.

“Where did I get it? How would this old man know? You’re the owner. You’d know best.”

“…!”

“What? Is something wrong?”

“N-no.”

I managed to answer, then immediately muttered to myself.

There was one surefire way to find out.

Open Inventory. Summon.

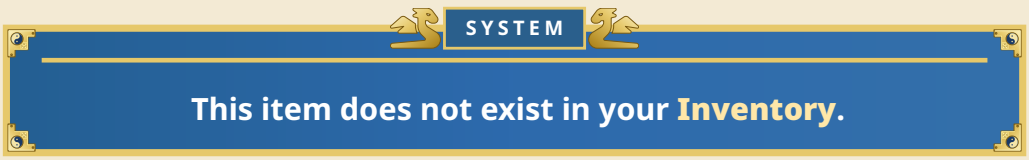
It was simple.

I just had to picture it in my mind and put my will behind the command.

But the process I’d gone through hundreds, even thousands, of times suddenly felt unfamiliar.

So did the small System window that appeared in the air.

Beep.



Shit.

I took a small breath and forced myself to speak calmly.

“I was mistaken. It is mine.”

“That’s what I thought. I’ve seen it a few times before, too. Still, it must have some story behind it. Or it’s important to you.”

“Excuse me?”

“I found it ten days ago, right where you’d collapsed unconscious. It was lying in a pool of blood, but luckily I recognized it. You’d carried it through such a fierce battle, so I figured I ought to keep it safe.”

“…I see.”

“Come to think of it, I’ve forgotten what it’s called. Chairman? Was it a makeup watch?”

I licked my lips, which had gone dry.

“A pocket watch.”

"Ah, right. One of those foreign devices used by the barbarians across the sea. It has such an odd shape that it stuck in my mind."

The part about barbarians across the sea was something I'd made up because too many people had been listening when I explained it.

As far as I could tell, this world wasn't even made up of five oceans and six continents. How would I know if there were blond, tanned punks or tyrannosaurs living across the sea?

But there was at least one thing I knew for certain.

That pocket watch had been buried deep in my Inventory for more than two months.

Had I taken it out?

A simple mistake in my memory?

Absolutely not.

I'd half forgotten the thing even existed. How could I have taken it out?

This makes no sense.

Right. This really made no sense.

The Inventory was an infinite storehouse that opened and closed only at my will.

But that thing—more precisely, the item called **[Pocket Watch of Unknown Make]**—had somehow broken the System's rules.

Without me even realizing it.

"I'd been meaning to give it back these past few days, but I kept forgetting, so I started wearing it around my neck. Good timing."

I took the pocket watch Jeok Cheongang handed me as if I were under a spell.

And—

"…!"

It suddenly came back to me.

"All right. It's time to go. To the place where you belong."

That fleeting voice, gentle against my ear, as my vision was swept away and pulled toward somewhere unknown.

"Take it. It's the last gift this old man can give you."

The hard feel of something I'd instinctively clutched as my consciousness faded, and the glimmer it held.

The Helper.

There was no doubt. At last, I remembered clearly.

The endless, empty space.

What he'd given me in our final moments there.

Squeeze.

I tightened my grip on the pocket watch without thinking.

Ding!

SYSTEM

Item information has been updated!
Would you like to view the new information for [Pocket Watch of Unknown Make]?
Y / N

After checking the System window, I fell into a heavy silence.

I kept my mouth shut on the way back to our quarters with Jeok Cheongang, while we climbed the stairs, and even when he prodded me, unable to stand it any longer.

No—I hadn't heard him.

The thread of thought holding my senses captive was that long and that tough.

What is it?

Memories that stay vivid long after the years have passed fall into two broad categories.

The unbelievably good kind, or the goddamn awful kind.

And the pocket watch in my hand clearly belonged in the latter.

Even after more than two months, I remembered it so clearly that I could recall every last word.

Item Window

[Pocket Watch of Unknown Make]

Type: Common Item
Grade: None
Restrictions: None
Description: A pocket watch made by someone unknown. Extremely sturdy. At a glance, it looks like an old, broken watch. Even on closer inspection, it looks like a broken watch.

The memory came back as fresh as yesterday.

The anger that had surged from deep in my chest like lava the moment I checked the item information.

How could I forget? It was such a goddamn awful memory.

Of course it was. Back then, I'd been bursting with anticipation.

This wasn't some run-of-the-mill Quest. The item had been given to me as a Reward for a **[System Update]**.

I'd gone through all that shit because of an update I didn't even know existed.

Right after defeating the Doppelganger in the modern world, I'd been sent straight to Murim. It hadn't been my choice.

The System Update had started without warning and forced me to Log In. The System stayed dead throughout the update, only returning to normal after I'd wrapped up the events in the imperial palace.

And after going through all that bullshit, how do you think I felt when I got this piece of trash as my Reward?

Considering how I felt back then, it's a miracle I didn't throw it away.

More accurately, it wasn't that I didn't throw it away. I couldn't.

It was an update reward, after all. I'd held onto a sliver of hope that it might have something hidden up its sleeve.

But it didn't take long for that last flicker of hope to burn out completely.

The pocket watch was… actual garbage.

It was filthy and worn no matter how closely I looked, and clearly broken no matter how long I stared.

I examined it like a judge on an antiques appraisal show scrutinizing a national treasure, but the only unusual thing I found was one faint line inscribed on the back.

A broken clock is right twice a day.

Twice a day, my ass.

After a week of watching the second hand stay exactly where it was, I shoved this sturdy piece of trash deep into my Inventory.

Whoever made it, I was sure I'd beat the shit out of him if he ever showed his face.

But… why is it showing up here again? And like this, out of nowhere?

I narrowed my eyes at the holographic window floating in the air.

Item Window

[Pocket Watch of Unknown Make]

Type: Special Item
Grade: None
Restrictions: None
Description: A pocket watch made by someone unknown. Extremely sturdy. At a glance, it looks like an old, broken watch. On closer inspection, it holds a secret that has yet to be uncovered.

The newly updated item information.

Actually, calling this an update seemed a little generous.

Only a few characters had been added or changed.

The item type, and the last line of the description.

The change was tiny.

It had gone from a Common Item to a Special Item, and the sentence “Even on closer inspection, it looks like a broken watch” had been replaced with new information. That was all.

But the meaning behind that change didn’t feel small at all.

Especially when I thought about how this useless piece of junk had come back into my hands.

The Helper. The endless, infinite space. And finally, the pocket watch.

I kept repeating those three keywords in my head, which was already crowded with thoughts, when—

Tap, scuff, tap.

Irregular footsteps drew closer through the slightly open door, and an uninvited guest arrived.

“Buuuurp. Whew. I’m drunk.”

A near-mummy—no, Hyuk Mujin—appeared with a burp like a lion’s roar and looked at Jeok Cheongang and me through half-lidded eyes.

“Well, well, you’re here, are ya? Hehe.”

Before I could say anything, Jeok Cheongang spoke in a dignified tone.

“If you’re drunk, go sleep it off. Unless you want the shit beaten out of you.”

Hyuk Mujin answered.

“Nah.”

“…”

“…”

Who knew one word could leave both me and Jeok Cheongang so dumbfounded?

But Hyuk Mujin, who’d just accomplished what no great fiend had ever managed, didn’t stop there.

“Uuugh.”

“Hey, don’t you dare…”

“Bwaaaaargh!”

“…I said don’t.”

What the hell was wrong with this guy?

Jeok Cheongang recoiled in alarm as vomit poured out like Niagara Falls. I sighed and patted Mujin on the back.

When he’d finished making a whole scene, he lifted his head.

“Huh? Isn’t this that watch? Are ya finally givin’ it to me?”

He’d spotted the pocket watch around my neck. Then he said something I never would’ve expected.

“But did ya finally get it up and running?”

“You crazy bastard, why are you talking about getting it up all of a sudden—wait, what did you say?”

“You repaired it, didn’t ya?”

With his tongue thoroughly twisted, Hyuk Mujin mumbled and grinned as he grabbed the pocket watch swaying before him.

“Ya did. It’s showing a different time than the last time I saw it.”

“…!”

What did he just say?

Chapter 1144

Was this what it felt like to have ice water dumped over your head?

I stood frozen by the last thing I'd expected to hear. Then I grabbed Hyuk Mujin by the shoulder as he grinned to himself.

"What do you mean by that?"

Whoosh.

As I spoke in a low voice, I sent a thread of internal energy into him. Focus returned to the eyes of the man who'd been swimming in drink.

"Y-yes?"

"Say it again. What you just said."

The alcohol had already fled.

Facing my completely serious expression, Hyuk Mujin swallowed hard.

"What I just said? Which part… Ah, the time?"

"Yeah. This thing. Do you remember it?"

I took the pocket watch from around my neck and held it close to his face. He nodded hastily.

"Of course. That was probably when we were staying at the Imperial Palace…? I begged you for it like crazy because I wanted it so badly, but you said you'd think about it, Captain. Then you never brought it out again."

Of course he remembered.

I'd made up some story about it being a valuable item from the Western Regions, and he'd pestered me for it practically every day after that.

"I'd pretty much given up when I heard you were giving it to Young Lady Ju. I didn't know you still had it."

That was when it happened.

Then, as he turned the pocket watch this way and that, still apparently fascinated by it, he finally said what I'd been waiting to hear.

"Still, no matter how valuable it is, what woman would want a broken watch as a gift? You should fix it before you give it to her."

"…Fix it?"

"Huh? Am I wrong? The last time I saw it, this long hand here was—yeah, right about there."

I followed his finger to the hour hand and felt my face stiffen.

"Captain? Did I do something wrong?"

"No. More importantly…"

"I'm sure of it. Why would I lie about something like this?"

"Right. You wouldn't."

That was the end of the conversation.

I muttered to myself and waved him away without another word. Hyuk Mujin understood the gesture and withdrew. Watching him go, I fell into thought.

Yeah. He's right.

My gaze dropped to the pocket watch resting in my palm.

Why hadn't I noticed it immediately?

There was no minute hand, as any ordinary watch would have, or even any numbers. But its one and only hand had moved a notch from its original position.

Not forward. Backward.

Unless it was designed from the start to move counterclockwise…

Had it gone around once—or several times—before stopping here?

And if so, what did that mean?

That old man definitely knew something.

The updated item information said the pocket watch held a secret, and The Helper had clearly known what it was. That must have been why he'd handed it to me as a gift.

But…

But how had he known something even I didn't?

And how had a pocket watch buried deep in my Inventory for months found its way back to me like this?

"…No way."

My heart suddenly began to pound, and my lips went dry.

Jeok Cheongang responded to the words that had escaped me, but my mind had gone blank except for the tangled thoughts I was struggling to unravel.

And finally—

"…!"

An unbelievable theory struck me like lightning.

Swift and decisive as the king's blade that had cut through the Gordian knot no one else could untie.

That endless, infinite space.

The pocket watch that had begun to move without anyone knowing.

And The Helper—an old man whose identity was a mystery, yet whose martial prowess surpassed anyone I'd ever met.

Our meeting within my consciousness had been brief, but I'd felt his presence. It was like a colossal wall.

Not even the Three Saints, the greatest masters under Heaven, had made me feel anything so overwhelmingly terrifying.

And there was only one person who could stand above the Three Saints.

The Martial God.

I swallowed.

A shiver ran from the crown of my head to my toes as I recalled the theory I'd formed about him less than half a shichen[3895] ago.

The System may have recognized Cheon Taemin's unconscious state as a form of death.

If that was true—

And if, for some reason, his consciousness had been preserved in the System—

Then I'd already met Cheon Taemin. The Martial God.

In that infinite space where he'd been staying.

No—in the Inventory.

Good call.

The voice I'd heard long ago echoed in my ears like a hallucination.

Along with the meaningless noise that had sounded at the end of my nightmare three days ago.

Tick.

A chill unlike anything I'd ever felt climbed my spine. I stared at the pocket watch, my gaze distant.

I thought about what the dream I'd had that day meant.

Why The Helper—the old man I now suspected was Cheon Taemin—had reminded me of a pocket watch I'd nearly forgotten.

And I knew the only way to answer all these questions.

"I have something to tell you."

After a long silence, my one sentence made Jeok Cheongang's gaze sink deep.

The grand banquet, where everyone had drunk together to their hearts' content, lasted only one night. But no one in Xining was sorry to see it end.

Blood was thicker than water, and stronger than wine. A few tubs of wine could never make them forget the blood already shed.

Not when they thought of the blood still to come.

"All preparations are complete."

High atop the city wall, Sword Saint Mae Jonghak began in a calm voice.

Not a breath of wind stirred.

Beyond the wall, countless troops had gathered across the fields beneath scores—hundreds—of banners. Their eyes, bleary with drink the night before, now burned like torches.

[3895] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is about one hour.

“Since the dark clouds of Dark Heaven first loomed over us, the realm has been plunged into turmoil and filled with screams. We’ve shed more blood than any of us can count.”

It was true.

Dark Heaven had risen only a little over two years ago. Yet the blood shed in that short time rivaled what had been spilled during the Great Faction War, which had lasted more than a decade.

“We’ve seen with our own eyes and heard with our own ears what their vile schemes have wrought.”

The conflict in Shanxi had been only the beginning.

Shaolin Temple in Henan had burned, taking the life of the eminent monk known as the Dharma King.

Soon after, all of Sichuan was drenched in blood. Then came Hubei and distant Nanman.

The Imperial Capital, Hebei, and even Gansu had been invaded.

“And at last, the will of the entire realm has gathered here in Qinghai.”

His voice, carried endlessly outward by his powerful internal energy, brought tears to the eyes of everyone listening.

They knew.

They knew how much blood it had cost to bring them here.

And they knew how precious and meaningful the blood they would shed from now on would be.

“We will hesitate no longer. We will not retreat.”

Fervor spread through the crowd.

This was their will—the will of the realm.

“We will fight not for victory, but to protect.”

Families who’d been with them since birth had died. Friends who’d supported them through hard times had died. Neighbors who’d traded smiles with them whenever they met had died.

And anyone fortunate enough to have escaped such loss would soon face it too, unless they fought back.

Unless they brought down the Lord of Heaven and the dark clouds that threatened to swallow the realm.

This was a war to protect. A holy war to exterminate fiends without equal in all history—and a mandate from Heaven.

“So I ask you…”

Shing.

A snow-white blade emerged from its sword case.

A purple glow surrounded Mae Jonghak as a vast wave of aura burst from him.

No—at his side, everyone standing tall upon the wall unleashed the countless feelings and surging auras they'd held back.

Along with the Alliance Leader's azure dragon's roar, which swept across the dry skies of Qinghai.

"Who among you will retreat in the face of injustice?!"

At that instant—

Clang, clang, clang, clang!

The darkened fields flashed like the sun.

Countless swords and spears rose high enough to pierce the sky. The troops' rumbling shouts and the force of their auras set the motionless banners flapping.

Yes.

At last, the wind was blowing.

A wind born in the Nine Provinces and Eight Directions swept in, bearing cold steel and the bloody scent of vengeance.

It rushed toward the cursed forbidden land beyond the distant desert.

Boom, boom, boom!

To the deepest, fiercest beat of war drums yet, an army of more than two hundred thousand advanced across the vast wilderness.

Murim.

No—the sight of a coalition unprecedented in the continent's history marching as one was magnificent enough to send a shiver through everyone on the wall.

But one man's eyes still trembled.

Damn it.

Jin Taekyung felt a weight settle in his chest.

This should be the end. Why did it feel like a beginning?

After countless hardships, the united blade of the realm was finally aimed at the Lord of Heaven. Why did he feel as though he were walking along the edge of a cliff?

Now's my only chance.

Unease pressed against a corner of his mind like a massive boulder, along with questions he still couldn't answer.

There was only one way to resolve them and move forward.

Master.

At Taekyung's quiet Sound Transmission, Jeok Cheongang gave a small nod.

So you've decided to do it after all.

That was all, and it was enough.

Before dawn, Master and Disciple had shared a long, deep conversation. They had no secrets from each other.

“Go on.”

As his Disciple climbed into the carriage they’d prepared in advance, Jeok Cheongang smiled faintly and added, “This old man will be right here, waiting with everyone.”

His Disciple answered with a smile just like his Master’s.

“I’ll be back.”

And soon, the Disciple fell asleep.

A sleep so deep and vivid that he wouldn’t know it even if someone shook him awake.

Chapter 1145

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, silently looked down at his Disciple, who lay comfortably before him.

His eyelids were firmly shut. His chest rose and fell with each quiet breath.

To anyone else, Jin Taekyung was fast asleep, oblivious to the world. But Jeok Cheongang knew what they did not.

His Disciple had gone not into a dream, but to another world.

The realm of immortals.

Jeok Cheongang clearly remembered the shock of first hearing the truth from his Disciple's own lips.

No—he could never forget it.

A world where skyscrapers hundreds of *jang*[3896] tall stood together like a forest; where the footsteps of humanity reached beyond the sky and into the universe; where supernatural powers that defied all reason ruled the land.

It was a world Jeok Cheongang could scarcely imagine.

But the place where his Disciple had been born and raised was plainly not as peaceful or beautiful as he had first thought.

"I have to go."

The previous night, Jin Taekyung's face had been more solemn than Jeok Cheongang had ever seen it when he said he intended to return home.

Even his Master had never seen him like that.

"Has something happened in the realm of immortals?"

"I don't know. Not yet."

"Not yet, you say. From the way you put it, something bad must be happening."

"It's only a hunch, but yes."

Jin Taekyung had brushed it off as *only a hunch*, but Jeok Cheongang, who knew him better than anyone, understood.

His Disciple never lied.

Behind his usual lighthearted manner, which sometimes bordered on frivolous, lurked a beast alert to even the smallest change around him.

That was why Jeok Cheongang could sense the immense anxiety and burden pressing down on Jin Taekyung's shoulders. He could feel, too, how his own heart had dropped when he saw his Disciple like that.

Perhaps that was why he had suddenly pictured his Disciple ten days ago, his body hanging limp in Jeok Cheongang's arms.

"Then say it properly this time."

[3896] A *jang* is a traditional Korean length of ten *ja*, about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

"What?"

"You just said you were leaving. As if you might never return."

Perhaps Jin Taekyung had been trying to spare his Master needless worry.

Jeok Cheongang had not heard everything about the place called the realm of immortals, but he knew one thing for certain.

However different the two worlds were, if the soul was erased, the body died too.

More than anything, he feared finding his Disciple one day in a sleep from which he would never wake.

After a moment of silence that seemed to last forever, Jin Taekyung smiled and answered.

"Then… I'll be back. I promise."

Why, then, did Jeok Cheongang still feel so heavyhearted?

He had heard the answer he wanted. Yet the weight remained through a sleepless night, and it remained now as he kept watch beside his Disciple on the long journey.

Another month, at the soonest.

That was how long it would take an army of more than two hundred thousand to cross the vast Taklamakan Desert in Xinjiang.

It was only an estimate, of course. But the coalition army had finished its preparations and calculations down to the last detail. It would press across the desert with unstoppable momentum and reach its destination.

Tianshan—the place regarded as cursed for the past thousand years.

Whatever danger waits there, it doesn't matter. This old man will protect you.

Those who know what they must do have no fear.

A Master belonged beside his Disciple, and Jeok Cheongang would not leave this spot until Jin Taekyung woke.

Nor would the others, who had arrived and taken up their positions without a word.

"What are you staring at?"

Jeok Cheongang answered the Slaughter Saint, who sat in one corner of the carriage with his eyes half-closed.

"There's an uninvited guest planted right there. I was wondering who the hell he was."

"Uninvited? Why would I be uninvited?"

"Because the owner of the carriage didn't invite you."

The Slaughter Saint snorted and nodded toward Jin Taekyung.

"You're mistaken. The owner of the carriage isn't you. It's that fellow lying over there. And this carriage was a gift from the Emperor and the Zhuge Clan, not you."

"But I'm his Master."

"By that logic, so am I. I taught him something valuable once."

"You mean that Ghost-whatever footwork technique? It wasn't much good."

"What? Not much good? Your lot at the Fire Gate Clan—"

"*Your lot?* You snot-nosed brat. How dare you speak to an elder like that—"

It was a bewildering exchange for two old masters whose combined ages exceeded two hundred, especially inside a carriage drawn by the eight finest imperial sweat-blood horses. Yet Jeok Cheongang felt warmth spreading through his heart.

Do you see? Your efforts and pain weren't in vain.

Not even one shichen[3897] had passed since the army began its full-scale march, yet the eight-horse carriage at the very back of the long, seemingly endless column had already received plenty of visitors.

Members of the Embroidered Uniform Guard who protected the Emperor's closest confidants. Masters of Murim, including the Nine Sects and One Gang.

Every one of them ranked among the most skilled in the vast army, and each had come asking to join the carriage's escort.

To repay a debt.

To show even a little respect for the great devotion and effort the owner of the carriage had shown until now.

If Jeok Cheongang hadn't sent them away with threats, there might have been more than a thousand of the finest guards surrounding the carriage by now.

A handful, of course, had stood their ground without so much as twitching an eyebrow at his threats.

"Good grief, there they go again."

"They've got plenty of energy."

"Shh. They'll hear you."

Familiar voices drifted through the gap in the carriage door. Jeok Cheongang felt a sudden swell of emotion and, before he knew it, let out a quiet laugh.

"Why are you laughing all of a sudden? You sound like a crazy old man."

"Who knows."

Even the Slaughter Saint's sour jab could not wipe the smile from his face. Perhaps it was because he was happy.

In this harsh world, he was not the only one who treasured his Disciple as much as himself and looked out for him. The joy of knowing that was small, and enormous.

Jeok Cheongang had long ago turned his back on the world and kept his distance from people. He did not want his one and only Disciple to walk the same path.

No. This boy had to be different.

He had to pursue righteousness, practice chivalry, and win people's hearts.

[3897] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

Now and in the years to come.

Always. Forever.

To see that wish fulfilled, his Master could do anything.

Even if hell waited beyond those scorching sands.

Without fail.

By now, Jeok Cheongang's eyes had sunk deep as he watched the vast desert outside the window.

Rumble.

A huge bank of dark clouds began to spread above the fierce heat shimmer.

Everything that happens in the world has two sides, like a coin.

Where there is light, there is darkness. When the sun sets, the moon rises.

Not long after someone closed their eyes in comforting warmth, the same was true of someone who awoke in a sealed chamber tens of thousands of *ri*[3898] away.

Though perhaps *opened their eyes* was the better way to put it.

The one who had just done so could never sleep again.

"What happened?"

At the low voice that seemed to ring inside his head, a subordinate shuddered and answered.

"You collapsed for a moment."

"I collapsed?"

"Yes. It seemed you had lost consciousness, but this subordinate dared not touch you…"

Crack.

Before he could finish, an invisible hand squeezed his throat. The subordinate's face went pale.

"You dare lie to me."

"C-cough. I-I'm not."

Instead of an answer, formless energy crept over him, binding his entire body and choking the breath from him.

The subordinate gasped and struggled to protest. Only when his body went limp did the energy pressing down on the chamber vanish as though washed away.

Leaving behind the realization that the dead man had told the truth—and one question that remained unanswered.

Lost consciousness? Why?

[3898] A Korean *ri* is about 393 m (0.244 mi).

The shadow left the subordinate's corpse behind in the dark chamber and fell into thought.

An inexplicable shock had struck in an instant, followed by a break in consciousness.

Even with all her vast knowledge, the shadow could not explain it.

The shadow rose as if floating, climbing thousands of steps. She stopped only when she reached the one being who could answer her question.

Rumble.

The enormous iron doors opened before the shadow could ask to enter.

In the perfectly complete darkness, where not a single glimmer of light could be seen, *he* was there.

"Your humble servant comes before the great Lord of Heaven."

The shadow cried out in reverence and immediately prostrated herself.

She already possessed power and stature far beyond human limits. Yet the pitch-black darkness held the power to crush her like an insect at any moment.

No—having grown another level, the shadow could feel that omnipotence more clearly than ever.

"I knew you would come."

She could even hear the faint delight in that flat voice, a voice that froze the soul merely to hear it.

"You must have felt the wave."

"…!"

"What surprises you so, Grand Sorceress?"

The darkness stirred and gently wrapped around the shadow's—no, the Grand Sorceress's—shoulder.

"Root and branch are one. Reborn through my grace, you must have felt it."

The Grand Sorceress's trembling eyes dropped to her own hand.

Rot had eaten through it, leaving white bone exposed: a grisly reminder that the body had already died. But the Grand Sorceress shuddered with joy and awe.

That was right.

She had been born again.

Blessed by the great and omnipotent Lord of Heaven, she had risen from death and returned to her master's side.

And at last, she understood the true purpose of the Lord of Heaven's grand design.

"Then the wave you spoke of just now…"

"Yes."

At that very moment—

Ssssh.

A faint green light rose in the pitch-black darkness.

For more than fifty years, no one in Dark Heaven had laid eyes on those snow-white fingers. Bathed in green light, they caressed a piece of jade.

Softly. Coolly.

“Once again, the heavens have opened.”

Chapter 1146

In a dark, narrow room, a man stood before a full-length mirror, silently staring at its smooth surface.

Tall and slender, with sharply defined features.

He had seen his reflection countless times over the past thirty-odd years. But what gripped him now was not familiarity. It was bitterness and anger.

“Why did it have to be you?”

The faint words slipped from his lips without warning.

Normally, he would never have muttered to himself. This time, he didn’t care.

“You’re not the one who should be here.”

Every word felt like breathing fire.

It ached deep in his chest, as though an invisible awl were digging into him. Beads of sweat had gathered without his noticing and rolled down his cheeks.

Like his heart. Endlessly.

“You’re not qualified.”

It was true.

Unlike the handful of people with the necessary “qualifications,” he had neither overwhelming strength nor the experience of a battle-hardened veteran.

But acknowledging that was one thing. He knew better than anyone how heavily this responsibility weighed on his shoulders, and how much this mission mattered.

That was when his trembling eyes suddenly flashed.

Crunch.

A sickening sound of torn flesh, and the taste of blood filled his mouth.

He spat out a mouthful of blood and faced the mirror again.

A man with a deep, unwavering gaze stared back at him now.

He looked uncannily like someone bound to him by the longest and closest of ties—and yet someone who had felt farther away than anyone else in the world.

But even that brief thought was a luxury for the man. For Choi Minwoo.

Crack.

A faint tremor traveled down from the ceiling, and hairline fractures spread across the full-length mirror like a spiderweb.

Sensing that the time had finally come, Choi Minwoo turned his back on his distorted reflection and flung open the rusted iron door that had briefly kept the harsh reality outside at bay.

Creeeak.

In the middle of a corridor barely wide enough for two grown men to stand shoulder to shoulder, a hulking figure wrapped from head to toe in a military poncho gave Choi Minwoo a nod.

“Right on time.”

“Sorry to keep you waiting. I needed a moment to prepare.”

“No need to apologize. You’re in charge here. Though…”

The figure glanced at the dust drifting slowly down from the ceiling, stirred by a tremor that had grown slightly stronger.

“Any later and we’d have been in trouble. Let’s go.”

As if they’d planned it, they quickly set off, trading words as they made their way through the winding, ant-nest-like corridors.

“What happened?”

The hulking figure answered Choi Minwoo in a subdued voice.

“I’d like to say it’s just a sandstorm…”

“It’s them.”

“Damn it. Yeah.”

Why did his worst suspicions never turn out to be wrong?

But Choi Minwoo had left his self-reproach and complaints behind at the broken mirror. He steeled himself and asked another question.

“How many?”

“From what we’ve been able to tell, at least several thousand.”

Several thousand.

It sounded like an absurdly broad estimate, but communications and every radar network had been down for some time. Choi Minwoo accepted the figure without question.

The hulking figure’s abilities were unlike anyone else’s in this old, worn-out underground bomb shelter. He was also someone Choi Minwoo trusted enough to entrust with his own life.

“…Several thousand?”

If there were already several thousand as far as they could tell, the number could exceed ten thousand, depending on the situation.

At Choi Minwoo’s darkening gaze, the hulking figure made an effort to shake his head.

“They might just be a scouting party. Those guys always move around in swarms like ants.”

It was a reasonable guess.

The enemy had already swallowed up a vast stretch of desert. Their numbers were terrifying, and growing by the day.

Even if they aren't here to attack, they could simply be passing through on their way to another city. Our routes might have crossed by chance.

Choi Minwoo walked on in silence, lost in thought.

They were staying in an underground bomb shelter secretly built by the US military during the Gulf War. It had been abandoned for more than fifty years after the war ended, and the Great Cataclysm had reshaped the land so thoroughly that even its existence had been forgotten.

Until a group hurrying across the desert happened to find its entrance beneath a sand dune.

If we only found it by luck, what are the chances the enemy knows it's here?

Slim to none.

The only thing that bothered him was the communication Magic they had barely managed to establish not long ago. But given who had sent it, the chance of the enemy detecting it was close to zero.

Which means…

At last, Choi Minwoo reached a conclusion.

This was a coincidence.

As the hulking figure had said, they were probably a scouting party, or their paths had simply crossed.

All Choi Minwoo and the others had to do was wait.

They could hold their breath in this old, musty shelter, let sand and dust rain down on their heads, and prepare for a fight just in case. Before long, peace would return.

The uninvited guests would pass right over them without ever finding the doorbell to their hidden home. Choi Minwoo could lead the others out of the shelter without a single casualty.

In just a few hours.

Yes.

That was the best choice.

…Then why?

The hulking figure's eyes widened when Choi Minwoo suddenly stopped walking.

"What's wrong? Is there a problem?"

After a brief silence, Choi Minwoo answered.

"No. There isn't."

"Damn, you scared me. We're almost there. Let's join the others before they start chirping like frightened chicks."

Shaking his head, the hulking figure started down the final corridor to the central chamber.

That was when Choi Minwoo noticed how his back bulged beneath the poncho, as though he were a hunchback.

And at the same moment, his tightly shut lips parted.

“What do you think the best choice is?”

“What?”

The hulking figure turned at the unexpected question. Beneath the hood pulled almost to his nose, hair the color of molten gold spilled out.

“What’s brought this on all of a sudden…?”

“I can’t tell what’s right or wrong. What’s the difference between the best choice and the worst?”

Choi Minwoo continued in a hoarse voice. His eyes had begun to tremble, just like the ones he’d seen in the mirror.

“Even now, more than ten times our number are coming this way. But if we keep quiet and wait, there won’t be any unnecessary casualties. They don’t know we’re here.”

Rumble.

The growing tremors shook the ceiling. The rumbling had grown stronger with every step they’d taken down the corridor.

“If we wait just ten more minutes, it’ll all be over. For us, at least.”

The last words came out weakly. The hulking figure’s gaze deepened.

“Say what you want to say.”

“Whatever they’re after, blood is going to be spilled somewhere nearby. Even with their numbers, they wouldn’t move thousands of troops for no reason.”

“Now that you mention it, you’re right. So?”

“Once we’re through this corridor, I’ll give the order as their commander. If they want to make it home alive, they’re to hold their breath and wait. They’re not to get involved, whether the enemy is chasing helpless civilians or Hunters.”

The words poured out of Choi Minwoo like water through a broken dam. He drew a deep breath.

Then he saw the hulking figure’s mouth in the dim light of a bulb nearing the end of its life.

“Yeah. I see what you mean. So…”

He was smiling.

“If you’re done talking bullshit, tell me what you really want to say.”

“…!”

“Come on, say it and get it off your chest. Like that guy we know so well.”

With the rumbling growing louder by the second, the hulking figure dropped onto the shaking floor, as if he wouldn’t move another step until Choi Minwoo answered.

“What, can’t you do it like him?”

Choi Minwoo clenched his trembling fist instead of answering.

He knew exactly who the hulking figure meant without hearing his name. He had watched Jin Taekyung from close by for a long time. He knew that, whatever crisis Taekyung faced, he always took responsibility for his actions.

And that was a gap Choi Minwoo could never close.

“Hunter Jin Taekyung… is different from me.”

“How?”

“I’m weak. I can’t compare to him. And I have a mission I absolutely have to succeed at, as the commander here.”

“Responsibility matters. But that’s got nothing to do with it.”

Before Choi Minwoo could respond to the cryptic remark, the hulking figure added quietly:

“The others still here are already planning to rush out and fight. Every last one of them.”

“…!”

“I stopped by on my way here and told them how many enemies there were. First thing they did was grab their equipment. They said there had to be a reason that many bastards were swarming around. Know what’s even funnier?”

The hulking figure let out a short laugh.

“I told them to wait for their commander’s orders. They said you’d be thinking the same thing anyway.”

He rose and approached Choi Minwoo, who stood frozen like a statue.

But he wasn’t the only one to move.

“Uh…”

“When are we heading out?”

Hunters had appeared at the far end of the corridor, their heads poking around the corner. The hulking figure shrugged at Choi Minwoo.

“There you have it.”

Choi Minwoo looked silently from him to the Hunters, who had already finished their preparations.

Then, slowly—

Very slowly, as a thunderous rumbling shook everything around them, he drew the sword at his waist.

“This is my answer.”

At that moment—

Hiss. Slash!

The aura surging fiercely along the blade split the shelter’s concrete wall like tofu.

KABOOM!

The explosion sent debris flying.

Beyond the shattered wall came blazing sunlight and the blood of cursed monsters.

“I like you. For a human.”

The hulking figure—the Skeleton King—laughed aloud and patted the large backpack hidden beneath his poncho.

“Don’t worry. I’ll keep you safe, you human who sleeps too much for no reason.”

And he shot toward the enemies.

Or he was about to.

If not for the answer no one had expected.

“Dad’s not sleeping.”

“…Huh?”

Chapter 1147

In that brief moment, split into smaller and smaller moments, the Skeleton King thought:

Have I been feeling a little weak lately?

Yes. He must have heard wrong.

They said that humans—strictly speaking, he wasn't human, and certainly not an animal—sometimes heard things that weren't there when their bodies and minds were weak.

Besides, they were about to fight enemies who outnumbered them by more than ten to one. With the odds so bad he'd borrow a cat's paw if he could, hearing things was hardly strange.

That guy—

No, Jin Taekyung was the most reliable person in the world to him.

But…

There's no way he's woken up.

It was all wishful thinking.

They'd faced countless dangers on the way to this old, musty underground bomb shelter, but every time, Jin Taekyung's eyelids had stayed firmly shut without so much as a twitch.

The Skeleton King had even begun to worry that he might never wake up at all.

That damn human.

Just as he thought it bitterly to himself—

Whoosh!

With a sharp whistle, the flow of time that had briefly stopped came rushing back like a flood.

KABOOM!

A powerful impact shook the space around them.

The Skeleton King's expression darkened as he canceled out a dozen or so streaks of light flying through the air.

This is…

There was no mistaking it.

Speed and strength on a level entirely different from ordinary monsters.

The Bone Sword trembling in his grasp told him that *those guys* were among the thousands of monsters. It told him, too, that this battle—now past the point of no return—would be even harder than expected.

"Shit, it's them!"

"Everyone, switch to a defensive formation!"

They were quick to judge, and quick to act.

Every Hunter here was a skilled veteran with plenty of combat experience. At the almost simultaneous shouts from the Skeleton King and Choi Minwoo, the Hunters charging behind their commander moved at once, without the slightest hesitation or sign of panic.

Or they did until a low voice stopped them in their tracks.

“Maintain the attack formation.”

“…?”

“…?”

Midway through switching to a defensive formation, the Hunters looked at one another in confusion.

First, because the order had suddenly changed.

Second, because Choi Minwoo—the only one there with the authority to give orders—looked just as strange as they did. Stranger, even.

And third—

I’ve heard that voice somewhere before.

They were sure of it. The voice sounded unfamiliar, yet somehow caught the ear at once. Though low and hoarse, there was something about it they couldn’t mistake.

Perhaps that was why the veteran Hunters, all of them battle-hardened, couldn’t hide their dismay.

And why they left a fatal opening for the enemies right in front of them.

—Grrrrrrrr!

Thousands of monsters surged toward them like a wave, roaring. Ghouls, Orcs, Lizardmen, and Manticores swung claws and weapons that could tear through steel like paper.

And then—

Whoosh.

A dazzling streak of light shot toward the fearsome monsters.

BOOM!

Flesh and bone exploded into hundreds, then thousands of pieces. Countless dying screams rose with sprays of blue-green blood.

In the thick mist of blood that enveloped them in an instant, those who witnessed the unbelievable scene suddenly understood.

Who had given the order they’d just heard.

Why that low, hoarse voice had felt so familiar.

“Hey.”

Over the shoulder of the Skeleton King, who stood rigid as a statue, a young man poked his head out of the backpack he’d been carrying.

“You were pretending not to hear me on purpose, weren’t you?”

"…!"

"…!"

Honestly, at first I thought I was dreaming.

Dreaming of a time before I was even born, when I was busy squirming around in Mom's belly.

I mean, who would think to fold up a sleeping person and stuff them whole into a huge backpack?

And judging by the turtle-shell bondage they'd done with those famously tough ogre tendons—like something out of a certain kind of Japanese video—whoever did this wasn't just crazy.

Of course, I knew exactly who that lunatic was.

"This bastard's tastes are seriously… No, let's talk about that later."

"You, you…!"

Leaving the Skeleton King stammering behind me with a look like he'd seen a ghost, I put strength back into my stiff body.

Crack, crack.

I snapped the ogre tendons binding me from head to toe like strands of thread, tore through the backpack made of equally tough hide, and stood on my own two feet. Only then did I feel like I could breathe.

How long was I like that?

I had questions lined up on the tip of my tongue. But I knew this wasn't the time to ask.

From the moment I regained consciousness until now, the stench boiling all around me and the thick magical power had been enough to make me nauseous.

"Team Leader."

I gave a slight nod in greeting. Team Leader Choi, watching me with a jumble of emotions on his face, finally let out the breath he'd been holding.

"Everyone, form up for an attack."

At once, the air around us began to boil.

The Skeleton King and Team Leader Choi, whom I hadn't seen in ages, stood alongside some two hundred Hunters of various races. Eyes alight, they raised their weapons and took their places.

Like a single arrow.

And the direction it would fly was already decided.

CRUNCH, clack!

White Flame returned to my hand after piercing dozens of monsters, just as it had on its way out. It trembled in my grasp as though it sensed what was about to come.

“Let’s go.”

That was all I said.

Nothing more, nothing less.

The thought became a sound, the sound slipped past my lips—and in that instant, I was already charging at the enemies.

Whoosh.

One step.

I closed the twenty-meter[3899] gap in an instant and brought White Flame down without hesitation.

Fwoosh!

Space warped before the deep-blue flames now burning along the spearhead. Terrible heat swallowed the monsters, and pillars of fire erupted from cracks in the ground, now as hot as a field of lava.

KABOOM!

Explosions and thunderous noise. Screams burst out all around.

But I paid no attention to the massive shock wave or the chaos.

No—more accurately, none of my allies did.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

We left the flying sparks and mangled scraps of flesh behind. The two hundred or so Hunters charged like the wind and tore the monsters apart with strength even I hadn’t expected.

Whoooooosh!

In a split second, countless streaks of light dazzled my eyes. Ogre hide—said to be impenetrable even to an anti-materiel sniper rifle—and Manticore tails split like tofu, scattering in every direction.

Slash, splatter!

The monsters’ encirclement crumbled amid fountains of dark blood.

At its center, the Hunters’ weapons shone fiercely with a power I knew well.

Aura?

My eyes widened despite myself.

There was no mistaking it. Aura, also known as Sword Energy.

A hallmark of A-rank Hunters in the modern world and the exclusive domain of Peak masters in Murim, it flowed along their weapons.

Not just ten or twenty of them. Every one of the two hundred or so Hunters.

[3899] Twenty meters is about 66 ft.

Why are there this many A-rank Hunters gathered here? The last place I remember being was more than a thousand kilometers[3900] from even the nearest ally.

What on earth had happened while I was gone?

I tried to recall what I knew of the modern world, but it was hard to make sense of the situation.

No.

Before I could even begin to understand the reality in front of me, another unexpected factor got in the way.

Ssssh.

A chillingly low whistle reached my ears. My body moved before my brain could react, bringing down White Flame's spearhead, which had paused for only an instant.

Slash, KABOOM!

It all happened in a flash.

I cut through a crescent-shaped mass of magical power flying toward me. The concentrated, sticky-cold energy swallowed the monsters to either side.

And then—

Splash.

A group came into view, stepping through a puddle of blue-green blood.

"…What are they?"

Team Leader Choi and the Skeleton King, who had moved up on either side of me, answered the question that had slipped out on instinct.

"It's them."

"Be careful, human. They're nothing like the monsters you know."

I looked at the uninvited guests instead of answering.

There were seven of them.

They looked… human. More so than even Lizardmen, who were called humanoid monsters because they walked on two legs.

But they weren't human.

It wasn't just their height, well over two meters,[3901] or their bulging muscles. It wasn't even that every one of them had exactly the same height and build, as though they'd come off a production line.

What is that energy?

Magical power too dense to be human, yet far too pure to be a monster's.

The Skeleton King was right. Each of them was strong enough to rival a Named Monster, with magical power purer than any monster's I'd ever encountered.

Like living things born with genes entirely free of flaws.

[3900] A thousand kilometers is about 620 mi.

[3901] Two meters is about 6 ft 7 in.

But…

“Yeah. They’re definitely different.”

The Skeleton King hadn’t been entirely right.

Step.

They weren’t the only ones on a different level.

And he had the wrong idea about who needed to be careful.

Slash.

I moved in an instant no one there could see or sense, feeling the sensation travel up the spearhead as I thought to myself:

Six left.

Chapter 1148

For a martial artist, growing stronger meant more than sharper senses. It meant greater concentration, too.

The terrifying focus to pour everything he had into a single instant, no matter what was happening around him, with only one thought in mind.

That was Jin Taekyung now.

Ding.

A familiar chime rang in his ears.

But his senses, honed as keen as a blade forged by a master craftsman, didn't dull in the slightest.

If anything, they sharpened further.

What was that?

The sudden appearance of the mysterious Named Monsters.

He'd already killed one, but what came first wasn't satisfaction. It was the heavy impact he'd felt through his spear and an inexplicable wariness. He moved faster still.

Flash.

A flawless Shifting Form and Position left not even an afterimage.

Six bolts of magical power fired a beat too late and pierced empty air. At the same instant, White Flame spewed fire again in Jin Taekyung's hands.

Fwoosh—KABOOM!

Space warped along the spearhead's slanting downward arc. Deep-blue flames, carrying a tremendous amount of Scorching Yang Qi, sliced through another Named Monster.

Or so it seemed.

Then Jin Taekyung felt the powerful recoil through the spearhead.

CRUNCH!

"…!"

Eyes wide, he watched the Named Monster hurtle away.

And he understood the wariness he'd felt when he killed the first one.

They're tough.

He didn't mean their movements or their aura. Their bodies were, quite literally, damn tough.

Tough enough that even he, after bringing down countless enemies, could hardly believe it.

White Flame can't even cut all the way through?

What kind of weapon was White Flame?

It was a ridiculously overpowered item he'd never have laid eyes on if the System hadn't showered him with rewards early on. In Murim, no amount of money could buy a treasure like it.

Even modern artifacts decked out with cutting-edge technology and every kind of Magic couldn't match the sharpness and strength of White Flame itself.

Yet its Force-wreathed spearhead couldn't slice through these monsters like tofu. Their bones in particular were denser than he'd ever imagined.

The monster had suffered a horrific wound, of course. But it was still standing when it should have been split cleanly from collarbone to pelvis. That alone shocked Jin Taekyung.

Its incredible regenerative ability, already restoring the wound in an instant, was just a bonus.

"How is this even possible?"

The question escaped his lips. The Skeleton King, who had joined him by now, answered.

"I thought the same thing at first. But think about it. It's not so hard to understand."

"Why not?"

"If a human as monstrous as you exists, why can't monsters like them?"

"Are you kidding? I'm an exception."

"Do you have to say something that puts me off my food like it's the most natural thing in the world?"

"Off your food? You've really become Korean. Weren't you supposed to be playing a foreigner?"

The question had been based on reasonable evidence, but Mr. Stone-King, from Atlanta, Georgia, had just learned a lot from a marvel of civilization called a smartphone.

"I'm Korean American."

"…You've gotten pretty good with words since I last saw you."

"Words aren't the only thing I've gotten better at."

WHOOOOSH.

No sooner had he spoken than a tremendous mass of magical power swelled around him.

Jin Taekyung blinked at the unmistakable difference between his power now and before. The Skeleton King shrugged.

"What? Trembling at my might?"

"…What the hell happened while I was gone?"

"A lot. But I can't tell you about it right now."

He was right about that much.

Not far away, Choi Minwoo was leading the Hunters in a fierce battle against the monsters, while the six Named Monsters had formed a semicircle around them.

Ssshhh.

Magical power, dense enough to take shape, rippled like fog.

Behind the skull masks covering their faces, emotionless eyes fixed on the two of them like blades.

“Go for the neck. It’s the easiest part to cut.”

With the Skeleton King now at his back, Jin Taekyung adjusted his grip on the spear.

“I know.”

“We’ll take half each. Three for me, three for you.”

“Can you handle that? You’re weak as hell.”

“Arrogant human. Did you plant a knife in your tongue?”

The Skeleton King stopped grumbling. Then he added, so quietly Jin Taekyung could barely hear him:

“Still… it’s good to see you.”

What was that?

“I said I’m damn glad to see you again, even if it had to be like this.”

Jin Taekyung tried to think of an answer, then simply laughed.

Before an awkward silence could settle, he pushed off the ground and charged at the enemy.

And, just as his monster friend had done, he answered in a voice barely above a whisper.

“Yeah. Me too.”

It all happened almost at once.

Whoosh!

The wind rushing over him swallowed his voice. Jin Taekyung shot forward faster than sound and reached the monsters a step ahead of the Skeleton King.

KABOOM!

Three swords met one spearhead with a deafening crash.

It was no even match. The monsters gave ground under the force of the blow, and Jin Taekyung kept advancing.

KABOOM! KABOOM! CRUNCH!

Amid the successive crashes, one Named Monster failed to keep up with his strength and speed and dropped to its knees. Jin Taekyung didn’t hesitate.

Slash!

He felt the heavy resistance through the spearhead.

He put even more strength than usual into the strike, and a head in a pure-white skull mask rose into the air.

Two swords were already swinging at him from either side, but they came half a beat too late to reach him.

No—the punch he threw after they'd begun to swing struck empty air first.

WHUMP!

Compressed air exploded.

As if he'd struck a mountain to hit the cow behind it, the shock wave burst outward, driving the monsters back and opening a gap.

An opening that lasted only an instant, but could decide who lived and who died.

Whoosh!

The sequence of movements didn't need so much as a preparatory motion.

With physical abilities that made even *superhuman* sound inadequate, Jin Taekyung threw his spear.

THUNK!

It shot through the air as though plunging from above and pierced another Named Monster.

Just as he'd intended, the spearhead slipped precisely between its bones.

CRUNCH!

Skin and flesh tougher than the hide of a large monster like an ogre were no use this time.

White Flame's Ten-Thousand-Year Cold Iron spearhead punched through its target and drove deep into the ground. Leaving the monster thrashing like a fish on a harpoon, Jin Taekyung pushed off the ground again.

And used the ability granted to him alone.

Inventory open. Summon. Summon. Summon.

Whoosh, whoosh, whoosh!

A dozen or so daggers streaked through the air like beams of light.

The only Named Monster still on its feet swung a sword brimming with magical power and knocked every dagger aside.

By then, it was too late.

Slip.

Moving with the subtle principles of Ghost Illusory Slaughter Step, Jin Taekyung slipped deep inside its reach and swung the last dagger, the one he'd kept in his hand.

He spoke quietly.

"You're damn tough, but…"

Slash!

"That doesn't mean you're strong."

THUD.

The towering figure, well over two meters[3902] tall, crumpled to the ground.

And at that moment—

Rumble.

A vast tremor shook space itself, and a dazzling flash spread above everyone's heads.

Maybe it was thanks to the enlightenment I'd gained during the past few months in Murim.

I felt a strange sense of familiarity before anyone else did. At the same time, I sensed an immense aura suddenly looming high overhead.

Shit, again?

Naturally, my first thought was that another unexpected enemy had arrived.

Another powerful being like the mysterious Named Monsters I'd brought down, and the ones the Skeleton King was still fighting.

Maybe that was why everyone on the ground froze as the tremendous rumbling shook the sky.

But why?

A terrible possibility had flashed through my mind like lightning, yet the red warning light my instincts always set off remained quiet, even as the flash swallowed the sky.

No. The larger that flash grew, the calmer I felt.

The Skeleton King, who had just taken down his second Named Monster and was locked in a desperate fight with the last one, didn't seem to feel the same way.

"Uh? Uh, hey!"

His pupils were shaking like an earthquake measuring 8.0, tsunami included.

He glanced up at the sky with a look that said, *What the hell is that?* Then he shouted at me, standing stock-still.

"What are you doing? Quit gawking and do something!"

"Okay."

I obediently raised both hands and waved.

At the sky.

"What are you doing, you bastard?!"

"Saying hello."

"…What?"

My helpful explanation didn't seem to clear things up. I grinned at him.

[3902] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.

“Someone came a long way to get here. I should at least say hello.”

“What the hell are you—!”

The Skeleton King could hold it in no longer. He burst out in anger—

At that very moment—

FLASH!

The light gathering in the sky exploded.

Within the blinding flash that spread in every direction, a different, destructive energy suddenly surged.

WHOOOOOSH!

I opened my arms wider still.

Toward the countless streaks of light pouring down like lightning, like arrows, with a fierce whistle—aimed only at the monsters.

Toward the one who had brought all this about.

My friend, and a great Grand Mage.

Chapter 1149

The battle didn't take long to end.

By the time most of the seven named monsters leading the enemy were dead or incapacitated, the tide had already turned. Then humanity's greatest War Mage arrived and smashed the monster army's life support.

KWA-BOOOOM!

Attack spells rained down without pause from dozens of meters[3903] overhead, tearing up the ground and sending blood spraying. His aim was nearly perfect, as if he were sniping his targets.

That was the end of the battle.

What followed was a one-sided massacre.

"Charge! Wipe them all out!"

CRUNCH!

With me, the Skeleton King, and Team Leader Choi at their center, some three hundred Hunters swept forward like a wave and swallowed enemies more than ten times their number.

Slash, splatter!

I cut down or stabbed every enemy that came into view. The medium and large monsters that trusted their strength and fought to the end, and the ones who had finally lost their nerve and turned to run.

No exceptions. No mercy.

After a little over thirty minutes of pursuit and slaughter, not a single monster stood on two feet in the blood-soaked desert.

Well.

Actually, there was one.

"Thankfully, we didn't suffer any casualties… What's that insolent look for, human?"

The Skeleton King had started toward me, then hesitated and stopped. I glanced over at him.

"Hmm. It's nothing."

"Looks like something to me."

"There are exceptions to every rule. Right?"

"Where'd that come from?"

"It's a thing. It has nothing to do with you, so don't ask."

[3903] A few dozen meters is roughly 100–300 ft.

His eyes narrowed; he'd clearly noticed something suspicious. Thankfully, I was spared any further interrogation when a huge shadow fell across me like a lifeline from heaven.

"Gentlemen. I have a question for you."

Dark skin like dark chocolate. Enormous muscles. And a staff that looked more vicious than most close-combat weapons.

The towering Grand Mage descended slowly through the air. When he spoke again, his voice trembled.

"What I'm looking at isn't some damn mirage or illusion spell, is it?"

He stared at me in disbelief. I slowly held out a fist.

"Why don't you check?"

"Oh, damn it. Jin?"

Magic Johnson, the Grand Mage from the United States, pulled me into a tight hug instead of bumping fists.

Squeeze.

"…"

The firm, heavy thing pressing into my stomach was probably his staff.

It had to be.

It took Magic Johnson quite a while to calm down. Fortunately, his excitement had come entirely from the joy of seeing me again.

Yeah. Even for a black guy, that size and hardness would be ridiculous.

"Dear God. I can see you standing here, and I still can't believe it. When did you wake up?"

He was only just regaining his composure. I'd barely escaped the enormous arms of this Grand Mage of the physical school, and I couldn't help glancing at the staff tucked into his belt as I answered.

"Not long ago. It still doesn't feel real."

"Ah, I see. The last time I managed to get in touch, I hadn't heard you'd woken up."

"What?"

Something about that phrasing made the dread I'd been trying to suppress stir inside me.

This was the modern world. Humanity had prospered so much that even *global community* seemed too small a phrase for it.

With Magic added to the advanced technology we already possessed, civilization had risen from the ashes of the Great Cataclysm brighter than at any other point in human history.

And yet…

The last time he managed to get in touch?

For a moment, I couldn't make sense of it.

Magic Johnson was a Grand Mage. One of only three masters of Magic among billions of people—no, only two now.

True, as a War Mage, most of his Magic was geared toward combat. But a Grand Mage could turn imagination into reality. One teleportation spell could carry him hundreds, even thousands, of kilometers.[3904] Given the right conditions, he could contact someone just as far away whenever he wanted.

So his choice of words wasn't merely strange. It was ominous.

He sounded like a signalman who'd barely managed to reach his allies through a broken radio.

Everything about this was telling me the same thing.

It was finally time to face reality.

"Johnson."

"Yeah?"

"When was that last contact?"

"Well…"

Magic Johnson trailed off. Then, as if something had just occurred to him, he turned to the Skeleton King beside him.

"Could it be…?"

The Skeleton King muttered as though making an excuse.

"Damn it. I didn't have time to tell you."

"…Shit."

"I couldn't have told you, either."

More precisely, I hadn't been able to bring myself to ask.

I'd been that afraid. That scared.

How long?

What had happened while I was gone? How much time had passed?

I let out a quiet, trembling breath. Magic Johnson looked at me and sighed deeply.

"Fuck."

It hurt to tell me. It would hurt to hear it.

But putting it off would only make it worse.

"Tell me. Right now."

And the very next moment, the answer I'd been waiting for came from over Magic Johnson's shoulder.

"The last contact was a day ago. Twenty-one hours ago, to be exact."

Team Leader Choi.

[3904] 100 km is about 62 mi; 1,000 km is about 620 mi.

Monster blood and bits of flesh had dried on his armor and sword. His gaze was drier than sand, and it pierced me like an awl.

“The first contact was three hours before that.”

Twenty-four hours. One day.

The numbers leaving Team Leader Choi’s lips seemed to grow thousands of times heavier, crushing my chest. My vision went white—whiter than all the flashes Magic Johnson had unleashed on the monsters combined.

No way.

A difference in the flow of time far beyond any ratio we’d seen before.

But that wasn’t all.

Even before Team Leader Choi spoke again, I knew instinctively that a crueler truth was coming.

“And…”

In the vast silence pressing down around us, he drew a deep breath. His voice trembled as he continued.

“Today is the tenth day since you lost consciousness.”

“…!”

At that moment—

Dum, dum, dum.

A war drum sounded, low and ominous. Before my eyes appeared a new kind of System window, unlike any I’d seen in Murim.

> **System** A trigger has activated due to the failure of the Main Quest, Cataclysm.
>
> **Mission:** Prevent the Summoning (Failed)
>
> You defeated the “Final Abyss” Doppelganger, but did not complete the mission.
>
> As a result of the Main Quest’s failure, the boundary of the Demon Realm has partially opened. Unknown beings are invading this world.
>
> A rift is in progress. Its progress will change when certain conditions are met and can be checked through the System.

The words were the same ones that had been etched clearly in my last memory of the modern world.

But a new holographic window appeared over them, bearing the name of a being I’d never seen or heard of.

> **System** An unknown being willingly answers the summoning.

> The immense shadow of Black Dragon Duke Morgoth has fallen over this world.
>
> Would you like to view the new Main Quest, Rift and Collapse?

Frozen like a statue, I suddenly remembered.

The enormous wings I'd seen in that meaningless nightmare on my last night in Murim.

The dragon's roar, shaking the sky swallowed by darkness.

The man was black as pitch.

His hair reached his calves, and his eyes looked as though they'd been set with obsidian. The only part of him that wasn't black was his irises. They shone silver, whiter than white, and were captivating enough to make anyone feel as though they might be drawn in.

Anyone, that is, except the old man calmly watching him enter his office.

Step. Step.

Footsteps echoed in the silence.

The man crossed the long carpet. Only when he came right up to the old man did the old man speak.

"You have no manners."

The man answered with a look, and the old man went on.

"A guest should wipe his shoes before coming in. You've dirtied the carpet."

"Ah."

At the man's soft exclamation, something stirred in the old man's chest. If not for the blood and scraps of human flesh scattered along his path, the old man might even have taken an immense liking to him.

"My apologies. I'm still a little clumsy with things like this."

The man smiled gently and offered his hand. Despite what he'd just said, the movement was perfectly natural.

"Ah, have I got it wrong again? I was told this is how you do things."

The man tilted his head. After a moment's silence, the old man replied.

"No. I was only surprised by how practiced you are. Your appearance, too—and that handshake."

The movement was more than natural. It carried grace and elegance. And the man himself might well have been the most beautiful human being in the world.

But the old man knew better.

He had seen with his own eyes what the man before him had done barely ten minutes earlier: erased his beloved Red Square with a single gesture.

“So, Morgoth. What brings you here?”

Vladimir Furin, Russia’s dictator, gritted his teeth as he clasped the hand of the monster wearing a human face.

Chapter 1150

A handshake.

Two people reaching out and clasping hands—the most common greeting in the world.

Yet the moment their hands met, Vladimir Furin felt as though every handshake he'd exchanged in his life, tens of thousands of them, had vanished from his mind.

"…!"

Cold. Hard.

Steel?

No.

The man—no, Morgoth's hand closed around his as if it were made of a substance that had never existed in this world. Then it began to move slowly up and down.

Carefully, as though handling an ant in his palm.

When the brief handshake ended, a satisfied smile touched the monster's lips.

"Just as I thought. The humans of this world are fascinating."

A short remark, but there was a great deal in it.

Furin wondered if he'd heard correctly, then opened his mouth.

"What… do you mean?"

"Do I really need to explain?"

Morgoth settled into the seat across from him and looked over the objects on the table with curious eyes.

"An astonishing civilization, no matter how many times I see it. The humans in the world where I once stayed could never have dreamed of anything like this."

"…!"

"I didn't expect that reaction. Surely you already suspected there might be another world out there, like the Demon Realm."

Morgoth was right.

Since the Great Cataclysm, countries around the world had quietly conducted countless studies into whether other worlds existed apart from the Demon Realm. The research was still ongoing.

But suspicion was one thing. Certainty was another.

Morgoth had just confirmed the existence of another world—something that had been no more than a hypothesis.

And he'd told Furin where he came from.

Could it be?

Furin wondered if the monster before him might be more than a creature mad with bloodlust.

If that were true, there was a very real chance they might still be able to contain the nightmare that had been unfolding for the past ten days, even at this late hour.

“Then you—no, sir. Did you come from the other world you mentioned?”

Morgoth answered readily.

“Perhaps. Perhaps not.”

“What does that mean?”

“I told you. I said I once stayed there.”

“Then…”

“The humans of that world had their interesting qualities, of course. But with time, everything grew dull. I needed a change. Something powerful and decisive.”

Furin’s eyes widened as he grasped what Morgoth meant. Morgoth smiled gently at him.

“So I left. For the Demon Realm.”

“…!”

“Entering someone else’s service wasn’t especially pleasant, but in the end, it was an excellent choice. I’ve had the chance to experience such an interesting game, after all. Don’t you agree?”

At that moment, the hope burning in Furin like a tiny campfire went out without a trace.

“…A game?”

“Yes. A game.”

“Then everything you’ve done up to now was this grand game of yours?”

Morgoth sighed softly at the unmistakable tremor in Furin’s voice.

“Humans really are human.”

“What?”

“Good heavens, a game? Don’t judge me by such a base way of thinking. That was merely punishment.”

“Punishment? What are you—”

“Ignorance is a sin, too. If they had bowed down and obeyed from the start, none of it would have happened. But they rejected my generous offer, and I had no choice but to give them a fitting punishment. That’s all.”

At last, Furin understood how much darkness—how much madness—the being before him held inside.

A game? Punishment?

Neither was right.

What Morgoth had done was a catastrophe. A massacre on a scale unseen since the Great Cataclysm ended.

There had been several major incidents since the Arch Lich appeared about a year ago, but they were nothing compared with the past ten days.

The estimated number of dead and injured had already reached fifty million.

The Middle East—more precisely, North Africa and West Asia—had already become a land of death with the Black Dragon's arrival.

Those who resisted were slowly rotting or had become undead. Those who survived had sworn absolute obedience and become slaves.

Not Hunters chosen by God. Not even heavily armed armies.

None of them could break the Black Dragon's massive wings.

This world already belonged to him.

"You're insane. Completely insane," Vladimir Furin muttered weakly.

Then Morgoth's smile deepened.

"Insane? Me?"

"Are you going to deny it? After killing so many people?"

"Of course not. I'm simply disappointed beyond words."

The Black Dragon's abyssal eyes fixed on the dictator as though they could pierce straight through him.

"How can someone like you dare to say that?"

"…!"

"Of course, I understand to some extent. I know from experience how shallow humans can be—and how wealth and power corrupt you. But…"

Ting.

A long, pale finger tapped the teapot. Inside, the black tea once regarded as practically synonymous with Furin rippled.

"Spare me the half-baked hypocrisy. It's an insult to my intelligence."

"You—you…"

"Yes, I already know a great deal. Though it would be more accurate to say I learned it through you."

Morgoth had lived for an immensely long time. Longer than anyone could imagine.

Yet even to him, the modern world of the twenty-first century was fascinating.

Human history. The fusion of Magic and technology. The structures and ideologies of governments.

And the countless conflicts, large and small, that had taken root all over the world as a result.

This civilization was unlike anything he had seen before, and it stirred his thirst for knowledge. His mind, which knew neither forgetfulness nor limits, absorbed everything he saw and heard in an instant.

That included information about a certain dictator who ruled the largest territory in the world.

"I found you impressive. In more ways than one."

Vladimir Furin felt himself grow strangely calm.

The monster before him—a living calamity, a Dragon—already knew everything about him.

No, perhaps even more than Furin could imagine.

Whether Morgoth had learned it while laying waste to the Middle East and other parts of the world, or from the contents of a palm-sized smartphone, no longer mattered.

All that remained were fate and choice.

And so the old dictator of the Russian Federation finally took off the mask of hypocrisy he'd worn to the very end.

"So? Did you come here for my autograph?"

"Oh, you've grown rather composed."

"I have no reason to feel ashamed."

"Good. Now I feel my visit was worthwhile."

Morgoth regarded Furin with amusement.

"Then I'll get straight to the point. Surrender."

"Become a slave?"

"Well, this world has a fine word for it: citizen."

"But they're slaves in all but name. Everyone knows what happened to those who surrendered to you."

"Then this should be easy. You must also know that countless humans survived thanks to their peaceful, wise decision to surrender."

"You still don't understand humans very well. We don't call scraping by from one day to the next like ants *living*. And we certainly don't want to be raised like livestock behind a fence, only to be slaughtered."

It was a shameful thing for a dictator to say after spending more than fifty years in power devoted to control and oppression. Furin didn't care in the slightest.

His shrewd eyes gleamed as he continued.

"I trust that's answer enough. So let me ask again. Why did you really come here?"

"What?"

"I've wondered about it all along. Why would someone like you go to this much trouble? And before you answer, spare me any nonsense about it being a game."

Furin picked up a cigar laid neatly on the table and lit it. He stared straight at Morgoth through the slowly rising smoke.

"Talking to you has only made it harder to understand. You regard humans as livestock or ants, yet you're trying your hand at diplomacy and negotiation? Whatever your true intentions, I don't believe it."

Different species could still follow the same path.

In that respect, Vladimir Furin thought he and Morgoth were rather alike.

They were rulers.

The gulf between them might be as wide as heaven and earth, but Morgoth, too, must have used his overwhelming power to rule over countless others as a tyrant.

And as far as Furin knew, someone with overwhelming power had no need for conversation.

Shamelessness became a natural virtue, while shame turned into something as old and musty as a grandfather's letter forgotten in a drawer.

If that was true of a mere human like him, how much more so of a Dragon whose very understanding of the world was different?

Besides, Morgoth wasn't the first Dragon to set foot in this world.

"One of your kind reduced Paris to ashes during the Great Cataclysm. It was more vicious and merciless than any other monster."

Morgoth replied calmly.

"I think I know the one. A few of them are like that."

"A million people were killed or injured in the battle against it. A thousand Hunters led by no fewer than four S-ranks died alongside them."

Another monster, Michael Silbert, had been born where that Dragon fell—but that had only come to light recently.

With the cigar's tip evenly lit, Furin put it between his lips and added.

"So why would you, with power far greater than that young Dragon had, go to such lengths?"

Silence settled over them, but not for long.

The man he'd questioned might not answer. Furin already knew the answer anyway.

"You've realized it, too. You can't fight every human. No, more precisely…"

Furin exhaled a thick cloud of cigar smoke and smiled. The old dictator was ready to lose everything.

"You're afraid of someone you haven't found yet."

At that moment—

Click. Rrrrrumble.

As the small button that had been concealed in Furin's wrinkled hand was pressed, a tremendous rumble rose from deep beneath the Kremlin.

Chapter 1151

The moment he activated the secret device that only one person in the world was permitted to use, Vladimir Furin thought:

This is as far as I go.

Was he reluctant to let go of life? Afraid of death?

Of course he was.

The more a person had, the harder it was to let go. That was human nature. And for a man who had ruled as a dictator for nearly half a century, there was no need to ask.

He wanted to live.

He had to live.

He had to raise the name Vladimir Furin to the level of a god.

He had to become greater than the tsars, who had ruled this land for generations by virtue of their noble blood, and greater even than the Iron Marshal,[3905] against whom no one had dared rebel.

But if that proved impossible—

If someone else appeared and tried to take everything he had built—

I'll burn it all down. With my own hands, so no one else can have it.

The old dictator, who had dreamed of immortality, smiled faintly.

Or rather, he tried to.

Time slowed, stretching out like a passing life flashing before his eyes. Then he saw the looter wearing a vivid smile.

"You really are an interesting human."

"…!"

Furin's shrewd eyes widened.

Rrrrrumble.

The enormous rumble, as if it would swallow the Kremlin—or Moscow itself—drew closer.

Slowly. Deliberately.

As though it moved at someone's will.

At last, Vladimir Furin saw the source of this unexpected phenomenon with his own eyes.

Wooooom.

Would thousands—tens of thousands—of bees swarming together sound like this?

Furin could only stare blankly at the vortex of flames rising through the melting floor of his office.

[3905] "Iron Marshal" alludes to Joseph Stalin; his adopted name derives from the Russian word for "steel."

Everything was red. Everything was hot.

Surrounded by an aura as dark as pitch, it had been compressed into a great sphere that blazed like a tiny sun.

And the old dictator, staring at it in shock, knew better than anyone that “tiny sun” was no exaggeration.

He also knew that a power once great enough to terrify the entire world was now in the grasp of the monster smiling at him.

Tsar Bomba.

The most powerful weapon in human history.

The mother and emperor of all bombs.

Only a handful of people involved knew that the most powerful hydrogen bomb of the Cold War—the one that had frozen the five oceans and six continents with fear—lay sleeping deep beneath the Kremlin.

They also knew that decades of secret experiments, carried out on the dictator’s orders, had given it a new name and destructive power far beyond what it had possessed before.

“Remarkable. Truly remarkable. To think you humans created power like this. What do you call this weapon?”

At Morgoth’s genuine expression of awe, Furin—sensing that everything was over—answered in a hollow voice.

“Vladimir.”

“What?”

Morgoth looked from the old dictator, already all but fallen, to the catastrophic power bearing his name. Then he laughed aloud.

“That’s a masterpiece. Or should I say, very like you?”

Morgoth found it truly amusing.

That a human granted barely a hundred years could harbor such enormous ambitions.

And that these mere mortals had tried to kill him, a being with power close to immortality, using a weapon they had made.

“Did you think this alone could bring me down? With Magic Gems taken from lowly monsters, you dare challenge me?”

At Morgoth’s words, as though he had already seen through everything, Furin quietly swallowed.

He was right. Tsar Bomba—or rather, the weapon now called Vladimir—was not merely a product of science.

The Great Cataclysm.

After that event had overturned the world’s common sense and order, one thought had taken root in the mind of the dictator who had barely survived.

I have to become stronger. So this can never happen again. So we can win any war.

And the means were close at hand.

Magic and Magic Gems. The new knowledge born from them: magical engineering.

And so Tsar Bomba became Vladimir.

As one of the world's great powers—and a dictatorship at that—Russia had countless ways to obtain Magic Gems for the experiments.

Of course, that meant violating more international treaties than anyone could count and killing even his own scientists and mages to keep everything secret…but what did that matter?

Mother Russia.

Russia—or rather, he—had to become greater still.

Even if a second Demon King descended, he and Russia alone had to survive and rewrite the world order.

Or die together.

Yes.

That was how it had to be.

Plop.

Ash fell away in clumps.

Despite decades of not smoking, Furin had managed only a few drags from the cigar. He stared at it blankly, then spoke.

"What are you going to do now?"

Morgoth didn't answer.

But Furin immediately understood the meaning behind the gentle curve of his lips.

"Right. It has nothing to do with me anymore."

The cigar trembled.

No—it was Furin himself who was shaking.

"Any last words?"

At Morgoth's kind offer, Furin raised a hand that shook like a leaf and brought the cigar to his lips.

He drew deeper than he ever had before, then blew the smoke toward the monster before him.

"No. But there's one thing I have to tell you."

He spoke the name of the man who had crossed his mind just before he activated the bomb bearing his own name.

"If Jin comes back, you're finished."

At that moment—

"I look forward to it. Truly."

Swoooosh.

With Morgoth's calm reply, the pitch-black aura restraining the catastrophic power slowly dispersed and enveloped its master.

Like the touch of death announcing the end of this land.

Whoosh.

A blinding flash swallowed the old, wretched dictator's final sight.

It was warm.

Eight meters[3906] long. Two meters[3907] in diameter. Twenty-seven tons.[3908]

Packed into a volume that could fill a large truck was the destructive power of fifty megatons[3909]—fifty million tons of TNT.

Those were the publicly known figures for Tsar Bomba.

It had enough power to make Little Boy, the bomb that turned Hiroshima into a land of death during World War II, seem like a little boy indeed.

But no one had expected it.

No one had expected this monster from a bygone era, born of the Cold War's displays of power, to awaken again more than eighty years later.

And no one had expected the monster's first cry after its long sleep to ring out from the Kremlin.

Gooooom.

The air trembled in an instant.

Everyone in the Kremlin—or rather, everyone in Moscow—felt that deep, ominous rumble.

The soldiers and Hunters holding their posts despite their fear. The citizens who had rushed into bomb shelters or out onto the streets when Red Square collapsed.

No one was spared.

Everyone felt it, and everyone instinctively understood.

This was the last moment they would ever draw breath.

And then—

Whoooosh.

There was light.

A terrible heat beyond human perception, atomic power mingled with potent energy drawn from countless Magic Gems—it all spread out, devouring everything in its path.

Endlessly. Greedily.

[3906] Eight meters is about 26 ft.
[3907] Two meters is about 6.6 ft.
[3908] Twenty-seven metric tons is about 60,000 lb.
[3909] Fifty megatons of TNT is an explosive-energy equivalent of about 55 million US tons of TNT.

Kraaaaaash!

In the storm of power, everything melted.

The living died. The lifeless lost their shape.

Underground or aboveground, whatever life they had lived—it didn't matter.

The blinding light that burst from the Kremlin made everyone equal.

Just as Icarus had lost his wings and fallen when he flew too close to the sun, the tiny sun born of a dictator's ambition and fear swallowed countless lives, including his own.

All of them, save one.

Rrrrrumble.

At the heart of the rumbling that shook everything around him, Morgoth lifted his head and surveyed the scene he had created.

Nothing remained.

Everything that had surrounded him just minutes earlier was gone.

Molten metal flowed in rivers. Above it rose a massive mushroom cloud, looming over the surface now transformed into a land of death.

It was quite a sight.

"Such power. I didn't even need to use Breath."

Morgoth felt both admiration and regret.

How could mortals be so greedy and yet so foolish?

They had saved him a great deal of trouble, but the place now shadowed by calamity was desolate beyond measure.

A city with a long history and a population of over ten million had become a land where nothing could live for hundreds of years.

"But birth awakens from within death."

The moment Morgoth spread both hands with those quiet words—

Pop.

The air stopped. The wind stopped.

And the Magic Gem energy that had swept across the city with a deadliness greater than radiation changed in response to his will.

Darker than before. Purer still.

Wooooom.

Dragon.

Great beings blessed by mana from the moment of their birth.

Morgoth had been revered as the strongest among them, yet in the end he had chosen corruption of his own accord. At his fingertips, space trembled.

Gathering. Compacting. Rising.

And at last—

Rrrrrumble.

It was built.

A gigantic castle unlike anything ever seen in this world.

His own kingdom.

In place of concrete and marble, it stood upon pitch-black earth amid air saturated with dense magical power. It was overwhelming, yet beautiful. Morgoth smiled as he gazed at its spire piercing the clouds.

Or, more precisely, at the camera lens of the drone hidden in the thick black clouds, watching him.

“Have you seen it, humans?”

That day, people all over the world saw it.

They watched Moscow disappear and a Dragon Lair come into being.

The calamity that had reached their doorstep.

Chapter 1152

There are no absolute secrets in modern society.

Cameras and the internet are everywhere, carrying countless pieces of information across the world.

And sometimes, a truth is better left unknown.

Like a Pandora's box that should never have been opened.

—KABOOOOOM!

With one last terrible roar—more than the speakers could fully convey—the screen went black.

The viewers watching a famous influencer's livestream from near the Kremlin knew instinctively what had happened. The stream had just passed one hundred million simultaneous viewers, making internet-broadcasting history. And they would never see the influencer behind that record again.

After several seconds of stillness, a single line appeared in the chat. It said enough about everything they had seen and felt over the past half hour.

> └ Oh, God.

A Dragon's wings crossing the skies above Moscow. Red Square vanishing without a trace.

The creature taking human form, just like them, then slaughtering the Hunters and soldiers who stood in its way as it strode into the Kremlin.

And then…

The calamity that engulfed Moscow.

Rrrrrumble!

The rumble traveled hundreds, even thousands of kilometers.[3910] It reached far beyond the rectangular screen and shook the world.

Countless eyes and ears—and even more cameras—caught the distant flash and the enormous mushroom cloud. The footage was quickly compiled into a single video and uploaded to the internet.

Its title captured the overwhelming shock and despair humanity felt at the news from Moscow.

—Where is God?

Where was God?

No one could answer.

No one.

[3910] One kilometer is about 0.62 mi; 100 km is about 62 mi, and 1,000 km is about 620 mi.

All they could do was hope desperately.

If God had truly abandoned them, perhaps someone else would appear to save them.

No.

Perhaps he would wake from his deep sleep as soon as possible.

And unlike God, too far away for their voices to reach, the savior of this new age answered their pleas before long.

“He has returned.”

At those first words from the flushed fifty-seventh President of the United States on the holographic TV, the whole world erupted once more.

The modern world meant something special to me.

It was where I’d been born and raised. A home I could never forget.

That was why I’d always loved it.

Compared to Murim, where danger and trouble lurked around every corner, I could rest here in relative peace.

But when had that started to change?

Like a broken gear, everything had begun to slip out of place.

And it happened faster, with consequences more terrible, than I could ever have imagined.

“So…”

What the hell was I supposed to say?

I kept trying to think, muttering words that meant nothing, but my mind had gone completely blank. Nothing came to me.

The hour-long video had just ended.

I stared silently at the black-haired man smiling at the camera in the paused holographic footage.

I wanted someone to break the heavy silence.

“I hear it happened three hours ago.”

At Magic Johnson’s low, subdued voice, the question I’d been holding back slipped past my dry lips.

“How many casualties?”

“…”

“Tell me. I’m prepared for it.”

Magic Johnson let out a quiet sigh.

“More than twenty million, even by the lowest estimate.”

“Shit.”

"Moscow, and the surrounding cities in the metropolitan area, were swept away. We've thrown every resource we have at investigating, but…"

He trailed off and bit his lip.

"There are no signs of life. They're probably all dead."

Erasure.

The word flashed through my mind. It was the most accurate way to describe what had happened.

"Vladimir. That fucking old man hid a hydrogen bomb in the Kremlin."

At the start of the Great Cataclysm, humanity learned two important things.

First:

No matter how tight the security, modern science couldn't stop teleportation magic.

Second:

Teleportation magic could move objects, not just people.

Objects like tactical nuclear weapons or hydrogen bombs.

That was why every nuclear-armed country in the world, led by the United States and Russia, had signed an international treaty and disposed of all weapons above a certain yield.

Or so we'd been told.

Until three hours ago, when a giant mushroom cloud filled the sky above Moscow.

"Russia is finished."

That was true.

For every other country, though, this was a beginning of another kind. A crossroads.

Resist to the bitter end?

Or surrender now and stay alive?

Black Dragon Duke Morgoth.

I repeated the name in my mind as I stared at the holographic screen.

On the land, blackened by magical power, a gigantic castle towered behind him. I took in his smiling face and burned it into my heart.

Can I defeat him?

The question came to me naturally. I realized my hand had clenched into a fist.

Dragon.

The unprecedented monster whose single appearance in the past had shaken the entire world.

But as his title, Black Dragon Duke, suggested, Morgoth was no ordinary Dragon.

He's strong. Horrifyingly strong.

I turned to the dozens of holographic screens filling the spacious monitor room and looked from one to the next.

A predator brought down a forest of skyscrapers with one flap of its wings, shrugged off a barrage of magic, and trampled Hunters underfoot.

Among those dying with one last scream were faces I knew.

“Die! Just die!”

On a crackling screen, a bloodied woman screamed.

Her lower body had already been crushed beyond recognition. Her abdomen was split open, her entrails spilling out.

Still, at the rear of her retreating allies, she drew her bow as if possessed.

She kept drawing until the Dragon’s claws came at her faster than an arrow and took both her arms.

Crunch!

Blood spurted along with the severed flesh.

A deep shadow fell across her face, twisted with unbearable pain.

“You foolish human. Didn’t you know this would happen?”

The Black Dragon’s question rang down from high above. She spat up bloody phlegm and answered.

“I did.”

“Then why?”

“Because we were taught to call this courage. Not foolishness.”

“Good. Then, brave human, would you follow me even now?”

“Fuck off, you monster. And…”

She grinned, baring her blood-soaked teeth.

“My name is Faye Chen. Not just *human*. Faye Chen.”

“I’ll remember that, human.”

“You’d better. Soon, someone incredible is going to come looking for you and ask about that name. Ask about… the name…”

Her voice faded. Then her ragged breathing stopped.

Her unfocused eyes stared into empty space.

The woman—no, Faye Chen—died just like that.

Hong Kong’s pride. An S-rank Hunter, a hero of the last Great Cataclysm, and my friend.

She had died a week ago.

How about we all grab a drink?

The memory came back to me.

The day we first met in Sichuan to hunt the Arch Lich, she’d suggested we go drinking. When I asked why it had to be that day, she answered:

Today's the kind of day you drink.

Huh?

It might be our last chance.

That day, we drank until we could barely stand.

Neither of us thought it really would be our last drink together.

"She was a good person."

A voice broke into my thoughts.

Rough and gravelly, it was different from Magic Johnson's deep voice.

"And a great Hunter."

I didn't ask who the unwelcome guest was.

The acrid smell of cigar smoke had slipped in before the monitor room door even opened, telling me who it was.

"Her sacrifice saved a lot of lives. Including one bastard who came back alive in disgrace."

Chuck Hagel.

Also known as Uncle Chuck, he approached slowly and put a hand on my shoulder.

With his right arm—the only one he had left.

"As soon as I woke up, I thought I should've died instead of Faye Chen."

"…Hagel."

"I know. It's meaningless bullshit. And I've repeated it hundreds—no, thousands of times by now."

Chuck Hagel exhaled cigar smoke and smiled bitterly.

He looked at the familiar faces and the deaths playing over and over on the dozens of holographic screens.

"I swore I'd never let anything like that happen again… Yet here we are."

What was I supposed to say?

No. What right did I have to say anything?

Whenever I needed them, they came running without hesitation. But when they needed me, I hadn't been there.

I hadn't stopped Morgoth's summoning. I hadn't realized soon enough that the axis of time had shifted.

And this was the result.

Ten days of indiscriminate destruction and death.

The weight of it all pressed down on my chest, more than I could bear.

Along with the anger roiling deep in my gut like lava.

"You know what?"

I let out the breath I'd been holding.

Reason and emotion tangled together. Then my mind went cold.

Before my eyes, Faye Chen died once more.

“From now on, I won’t let anyone else be sacrificed.”

I stared at her on the screen, my eyes burning.

At her warning Morgoth, with what little breath she had left, that someone was coming for him.

Yes.

That was exactly what would happen.

Chapter 1153

Everyone dies.

No matter how much wealth and fame a person amasses—more than anyone else in the world—or how strong their body and mind become, until they're called superhuman, they can never escape the shadow of death.

That was why we had no choice but to accept, however painfully, the news that our close companions had died.

No. We had to.

The reality before us was too horrific to let ourselves be swept away by emotion.

"…That concludes the meeting."

The lights came on with the presenter's exhausted voice, but the heavy silence pressing down on the room didn't disperse so easily.

Not until someone who had kept silent throughout the meeting finally spoke.

"Rest is important, isn't it? Especially at a time like this."

It was a simple remark, but everyone understood what he meant.

Anyone who couldn't read the room that well wouldn't have been here in the first place.

"I can finally breathe a little."

Once the conference room had mostly emptied, a middle-aged man walked over to the coffee machine in one corner and glanced at me.

"Would you like a cup, Mr. Jin?"

His hair was greasy and disheveled, and dark circles ringed his eyes. He looked like an office worker worn down by exhaustion. I shook my head.

"No, thank you, Mr. Presi—"

"You can just call me Donny."

"Sure. Donny."

At my matter-of-fact reply, Donald Doramp Jr., the fifty-seventh President of the United States, smiled faintly.

Even that was a forced smile. It appeared for a moment, then vanished without a trace.

Of course it did.

My eyes drifted to the hologram still hanging in the air. Its catastrophic figures were enough to wipe the smile from even a thoroughly jaded politician's face.

"When I first received the report at the White House, I thought, *Is this a dream?*"

He downed a cup of coffee heavily laced with potion and continued.

"To be honest, I still think that sometimes. I keep hoping all of this is one goddamn nightmare."

But it was real. The figures in the reports hadn't leveled off; they'd climbed higher every day.

Property damage in the tens of quadrillions. Tens of millions dead or injured, and even more refugees. The whole world was in a panic.

"That's why I had to announce as soon as possible that you'd returned."

As he said, the international community had moved quickly.

The UN Security Council, led by its permanent members, had immediately issued an emergency statement. News that I'd returned after going missing in the Middle East spread around the world before I'd even arrived here at the Pentagon.

"Some people thought it was too soon to make the announcement while we were still discussing it. But given the circumstances, we had no choice. If we made the wrong call—"

"No. You didn't."

I waved off the President's apology.

Because it was too late to take the announcement back?

That was part of it, of course.

But if the news of my return hadn't gotten out, people would have been swept into an even more uncontrollable maelstrom.

Disaster, after all, takes root in fear and confusion.

And the seed of that disaster had already blossomed, thanks to an unprecedented monster: Black Dragon Duke Morgoth.

"Jin, I've dealt with countless matters of national importance in my twelve years as President of the United States. But one issue has always come before all the others."

I knew the answer before he could continue.

Ever since Demon King Asmodeus descended upon this world, every country had been facing the same problem.

"The war against monsters."

Donald nodded at my words, spoken almost under my breath.

"That's right. Dealing with the Gates that remained after the Great Cataclysm—and preparing for the possibility of a second one—have been our highest priorities."

He stared silently at his empty coffee cup, then added weakly, "And those preparations failed. Or, more precisely…"

"Something appeared that was too strong for us to handle, even though we'd prepared for it. I understand."

Morgoth was that powerful.

Even if what I'd seen on the video wasn't the full extent of his strength, no Named Monster that had appeared since the Great Cataclysm could compare to him.

Except one.

Demon King Asmodeus, the absolute evil called not merely a calamity, but the end of the world.

And besides…

"But those preparations could only be complete with *him*, couldn't they?"

Donald nodded gravely.

"That's right. Our plan lost its strength when Sky fell into a coma."

Sky. Cheon Taemin.

If two atomic bombs had brought World War II to an end, Cheon Taemin had saved all of humanity by fighting his way through the Great Cataclysm.

Right. Just as the Martial God did.

I swallowed the words on the tip of my tongue. Donald continued.

"But Sky's absence isn't our only problem. Morgoth's power is a calamity in itself… but there's something about him that sets him apart from every other monster."

Once again, I knew the answer.

"Diplomacy."

"So you've noticed it too."

"I've dealt with enough monsters to be sick of them."

Just as I couldn't count every meal I'd eaten in my life, I couldn't count the monsters I'd brought down since my days as an F-rank Hunter.

So I knew.

Regardless of how intelligent or powerful they were, monsters were born with an instinct to kill.

If anything, the stronger they were, the more they wanted to crush everything beneath them. They tried to settle everything with overwhelming force.

Of course, there were exceptions.

The Skeleton King, who wasn't here, was one. The Doppelganger whose actions had led to Morgoth's summoning had even infiltrated human society long ago and worked in secret.

But Morgoth was different.

He wasn't merely bluffing or trying to deceive anyone. He offered surrender in earnest, and if people accepted, he guaranteed their survival.

A monster that keeps its promises.

And that had caused greater division than ever.

"Twenty-three countries have already surrendered to Morgoth. Along with the Arab League, which suffered the heaviest losses, several major South American countries have given up resisting."

"The Middle East has more or less fallen, but South America too?"

"What happened in Moscow had a huge impact. We tried to control the situation, but we couldn't stop the news from spreading."

Disaster breeds fear, and fear leads to fractures.

Faced with the most powerful desire of all—survival—people were crumbling one after another.

“Something similar happened early in the Great Cataclysm, but this is different. Everyone’s shaken.”

The reason humanity had managed to win the Great Cataclysm was simpler than you might think.

They united.

Ironically, it was their enemy, Asmodeus, who made that possible.

He truly lived up to the title of Demon King.

He killed those who resisted and those who surrendered.

He burned down cities and overturned mountains and seas.

Compromise? Promises?

To him, that would have been like a cockroach he’d found in his house one day pledging obedience in exchange for living there alongside him.

And so humanity had fought back with all its strength, united in purpose.

Fortunately, they’d had a savior in Cheon Taemin. They’d had no other choice.

But Morgoth kept his promises. Unlike Asmodeus.

He took human form and followed human ways.

For those who resisted, he offered devastating destruction and death. For those who surrendered, he guaranteed survival.

Like a cruel conqueror from the Middle Ages.

“If you hadn’t appeared when you did, I might be signing a goddamn surrender document right now.”

President Doramp smiled bitterly, but I couldn’t smile. My thoughts were racing.

I appeared in time? Me?

I didn’t know.

What if I hadn’t lost consciousness after defeating the Blood Lord?

If I’d woken up even a day earlier—or tried to log out just a few hours sooner…

Drip.

Blood drops fell, one after another. It was running from between my fingers where I’d clenched my fist without realizing it. After a brief silence, President Doramp spoke.

“Jin, it’s already happened. And nobody blames you. While you were gone, the rest of us were at our posts, and we still couldn’t stop Morgoth.”

I knew.

Ever since I’d gained powers unlike anyone else’s, I’d struggled at every turn. And as a result, I’d saved countless lives.

But the sudden surges of anger and self-blame still refused to fade.

They probably won't go away even after this is over.

People called me the savior of a new age, but I was human, just like them.

I fixated on what I'd lost instead of what I had, and feared the danger that was coming.

And that danger was closer than I thought.

"Mr. President!"

An aide rushed into the conference room. Behind him, I saw familiar faces.

Every one of them wore a tight expression, their eyes downcast.

The air froze in an instant. At the aide's touch, a holographic video sprang into the air.

Pop.

Through the constant crackle of static, a scene from tens of thousands of kilometers away[3911] filled the vast conference room.

A Dragon Lair rose over the blackened earth once known as Moscow, blocking everyone's view.

[3911] 10,000 kilometers is about 6,200 miles.

Chapter 1154

Everything in my field of vision was dark and murky.

The magical power that had erased even the radioactive fallout drifted as a blackish fog, and the walls, arranged in the shape of a pentagram, towered like mountains.

And—

Gooooooong.

At the center of it all stood that bastard.

Black Dragon Duke Morgoth.

KWAaaaaa!

In an instant split into ever smaller fractions, the gigantic black dragon opened its jaws, and an explosion of magical power burst forth.

A pitch-black pillar shot up from the highest spire and stretched endlessly onward.

It pierced the clouds and cleaved the sky in two, as if it meant to reach the distant moon.

No—maybe it really could.

It was the breath of the most powerful living creature in the world, and a roar filled with rage.

Dragon Breath…!

I barely managed to suppress the groan rising in my throat.

It was only a video, but the tremor and the atmosphere it conveyed were enough to awaken my instincts.

This was different.

I could say with certainty that it was on an entirely different level from any Breath I'd ever seen or experienced.

My heart was suddenly pounding wildly. The fine hairs all over my body stood on end, and the blood in my veins felt cold as ice. Together, they bore witness and passed judgment.

The One-Eyed Black Wyvern that had left me with an indelible trauma years ago.

The Water God Dragon of Dongting Lake, corrupted and driven mad by magical power.

Even Michael Silbert, who had made a Dragon Heart his own.

None of them had ever unleashed a Breath that powerful.

Perhaps it was the difference in their species itself, combined with the weight of power amassed over countless years.

So this is a Dragon.

Its terrifying power felt more real than a mere hologram. I couldn't help but shudder—and neither could anyone else in the conference room.

We even forgot to ask the obvious question: *Why* had Morgoth fired a Dragon Breath into empty space?

But the next moment—

Fwaaaash.

As I watched the sky turn pitch-black, I suddenly understood Morgoth's true purpose.

Rrrrrumble.

With a deafening roar, countless dark clouds surged in, covering the moon and stars. Then, like ink spreading through water, they took over the skies above Moscow for thousands of kilometers.[3912]

Like a single line dividing the world.

And the place where the abyss had settled resembled another world beyond our dimension, one humanity had only ever imagined.

The source and beginning of this entire calamity.

The Demon Realm.

"..."

"..."

Was this what it felt like to be struck by lightning right on the crown of the head?

The air had frozen. Those who grasped the meaning of the static-riddled holographic footage could only stare, eyes wide, unable to speak.

They clenched their fists as if they might crush them, gritted their teeth, and watched with bloodshot eyes.

At the same time, we heard it.

The cry of the black dragon standing atop the highest spire, calling out to the pitch-black sky.

"ᚠᚾᚷᚹᛖᚱ ᚦᛖ ᚲᚠᚠ!"

The roar seemed to ring out not in my ears, but inside my head.

It was more than a sound; it reached the level of will. No one here—or anywhere in the world—could understand the mysterious language.

Except me.

"...Answer the call."

The words escaped me in a groan.

Shaaah.

The clouds, swirling like the eye of a typhoon, parted.

[3912] One thousand kilometers is about 620 mi.

The roar that had shaken heaven and earth vanished, along with the wind that had been raging like mad.

All noise disappeared in an instant. With even the air seemingly still, the world looked impossibly peaceful.

Until a dreadful wave of disaster poured through the gap in the clouds.

Krrrk—KWAaaaaa!

The empty space rippled.

No—it tore open.

Hundreds, thousands of Wyverns and Drakes poured toward the ground, their bright yellow eyes flashing. Countless monsters clung to their enormous bodies and wings.

When the Liches cast their spells in unison, the giant monsters plunging from high above like meteors drifted gently to the ground like feathers. Death Knights raced through the air on ghostly horses and led their legions across the vast ruins.

They roared with joy and bloodlust.

—GRAAAAAH!

Clang! Clang!

Countless weapons swayed like a field of reeds in the wind.

Thud. Thud. Rrrrrumble!

The giant monsters, each one like a small mountain, stamped their feet. Hundreds of Liches and Death Knights went down on one knee, while ten times as many dragonkin cut through the sky with savage beats of their wings.

All in reverence for the one being who had brought them into this world.

But the black dragon's eyes were fixed on the camera, not on the Gate in the clouds slowly closing above, nor on the hundreds of thousands of monsters gathered beneath it.

"On my soul and in my name, I, Morgoth, master of the Silver Mountains and Archduke of the Demon Realm, swear this to you humans:"

The moment my eyes met the monster's through the hologram, I realized something.

This video was Morgoth's declaration of war—and his demand for humanity's surrender.

"If you resist, I promise you an end more horrific than any you have ever seen. If you surrender, I promise complete peace and survival."

But—

"If you wish to survive, come to this land, reborn under my rule, and swear your loyalty."

Even so—

"But everything has its price."

I hadn’t seen everything coming.

“Three days from now, I will sit upon the throne here and gladly accept the tribute you offer as a token of our eternal pact.”

Just how cunning Morgoth was.

“Just two humans—a paltry price next to the lives of billions of your kind.”

What his true purpose was.

“Make them kneel before me.”

The dragon’s eyes flashed, black as obsidian and swirling like the abyss.

“Cheon Taemin and Jin Taekyung.”

At that moment—

Ding.

A System notification pierced my ears with a chill, and a holographic window only I could see appeared, blocking my view.

Humanity was already recovering its stability faster than the various international organizations had predicted—or perhaps even faster than that.

The footage of Moscow’s destruction was enough to plunge everyone into an abyss of shock and fear. Yet a single fact announced less than a few hours later was like a ladder of salvation to them.

> ㄴ *He’s* back. ㄴ Oh my God. Please tell me this isn’t a joke. ㄴ It’s true. Official UN announcement. Turn on the TV right now. It’s on every channel. ㄴ Holy shit, that’s incredible. I thought we were all done for. ㄴ What the hell happened? I’m glad he’s back, but why did he only show up after things got this bad? ㄴ Because while you were becoming Pornhub’s best customer, he was traveling the world and saving people. He already came close to dying in the Middle East. ㄴ I’m genuinely worried about you, so delete that stupid comment before the FBI shows up in about thirty minutes, breaks down your door, and kicks your fat ass. ㄴ What did I do wrong? I didn’t do anything wrong. ㄴ He’s got a point, actually. The poor guy’s only guilty of having a lower IQ than a dolphin. ㄴ Yeah, don’t be too hard on him. If you happen to run into him on the street, just put a shotgun round in him. ㄴ You motherfukcer, you wanna die? ㄴ Oh, our Korean friend is here. He’s so worked up he even made a typo. That guy won’t be able to play games properly anymore. Koreans never miss a target once they’ve locked on. ㄴ And the Korean who gives him a headshot will probably be a kid around twelve. ㄴ Anyway, the important thing is that we’re alive. ㄴ Right. He’s back.

People quickly found hope again.

Ever since Morgoth appeared, the internet message boards had been frozen, without so much as an ordinary joke. Now they were lively again.

Everyone knew who *he* was, even without anyone saying his name.

That was what Jin Taekyung meant to humanity now.

Stronger than anyone, impossibly devoted, and able to overcome whatever hardship came his way and prove himself in the end.

Some still called him a second Cheon Taemin, but most disagreed.

Jin Taekyung had become the savior of a new age, one who needed no grand description.

He had done more than fill the place left by the unconscious Cheon Taemin. He had made it his own, dealt with disasters across the world, and saved countless lives. Who could take his place?

That was why people felt relieved.

Jin Taekyung was back. Surely everything that had fallen into disarray would return to its proper place.

Just as he always had, he would step in and set things right.

But less than a day later, a warning reached the Pentagon and the rest of the world. Humanity understood all too well:

“ᚠᚾᚷᚹᛖᚱ ᚦᛖ ᚲᚠᚠ!”

How futile their brief hope was before the vast army that had invaded Earth through a Gate unlike any before it.

“But everything has its price.”

And how they were already listening to the monster’s sweet offer.

“Make them kneel before me.”

How cowardly the desire to survive could make them.

“Cheon Taemin and Jin Taekyung.”

Once again, the whole world was thrown into turmoil.

Some were enraged, while others kept their mouths firmly shut.

The former called for a fight to the death; the latter hid their opinions to avoid criticism.

But another half day passed.

Rrrrrumble!

At last, people saw footage of the monster army that had seized all of Russia and was advancing in every direction. They had no choice but to fall silent.

All thinking the same thing, though they couldn’t bring themselves to say it to anyone.

Chapter 1155

“Russia has officially declared its surrender. General Vasily Gerasimov, current Chief of the General Staff of the Russian Armed Forces and acting president since the Moscow catastrophe, has…”

Beep.

“Eastern European countries, particularly Ukraine and Belarus, which suffered severe damage from yesterday’s catastrophe in Moscow, are mobilizing all available forces along their borders…”

Beep.

“We now bring you an update on the current disaster. Over the past eleven days, the world has seen an average of more than four Monster Waves and around fifty Mutated Gate incidents every day.”

“That’s truly horrifying news. Amy, what about the magical power distribution?”

“I’m afraid I have bad news, Steve. Today’s magical power distribution rose by 2.8 points.”

“What?”

“Yes. A full 2.8 points. If you’re having trouble judging what that means, take a close look at this graphic.”

“Here, it says the daily increase was 5.0 points. What’s the problem, you ask? This graph shows how magical power distribution changed at the beginning of the Great Cataclysm.”

“In other words, we’ve caught up to more than half of the magical power levels from the Great Cataclysm. In the Middle East, where Monster Waves and Mutated Gate incidents have been occurring in particularly high numbers, it’s no exaggeration to say that a second Great Cataclysm has begun.”

“And on top of that, the situation around Moscow is already… I’m sure you all know. There’s only one thing I can say.”

“May God be with you.”

Beep.

“Breaking news. Morgoth has accepted Russia’s surrender. As of 16:30 South Standard Time, the Russian Federation will disarm completely and, like the twenty-odd countries that surrendered before it, retain its current system of government.”

“Meanwhile, a large number of Hunter groups opposed to the decision have reportedly engaged monsters in battles throughout Russia…”

Beep.

“…I agree with part of what you’re saying. Our situation is extremely difficult right now.”

“Should we take that to mean humanity ought to surrender?”

“Not at all. I’m simply speaking on the basis of statistical evidence.”

“But according to what you said earlier, Doctor, humanity has no chance of defeating Morgoth, does it?”

“I’m beginning to wonder if your ears are attached to your anus. As I’ve told you several times, the chance is exactly 5.2 percent.”

“That’s an embarrassingly low probability. I’m sure our viewers are thinking the same thing.”

“I won’t deny the odds are low. But understand this: compared with when the Great Cataclysm first began, that figure is dramatically higher.”

“I know. According to that excellent paper that even won you a Nobel Prize, the figure was 0.2 percent.”

“Congratulations. Unlike your ears, your eyes seem to be in the right place.”

“Thank you. But I can’t overlook the fact that the 0.2 percent in your paper applied only to the period before Sky appeared.”

“True. But even Sky—”

“—had less than a 20 percent chance of winning right up until the final battle with the Demon King Asmodeus. Yes, I know. But unlike then, humanity has another option now, doesn’t it?”

“You!”

“It’s a reality too appalling to say aloud, but we can’t ignore it forever. Before it’s too late, we need to face the problem in front of us. Don’t you agree?”

“…”

“Thirty years ago, we had no choice. We could only resist with everything we had. But Morgoth is offering peace, and the countries that surrendered to him have kept their governments and are calming their people.”

“…Morgoth is a monster. A fucking monster. Do you really not understand what that cunning bastard wants?”

“I know exactly what people want. Peace. A chance to protect the lives of the people they love.”

“Bullshit. Listen, young man, cut the nonsense. You’re nothing but a despicable coward. You’re hypnotizing yourself into thinking you speak for all of humanity while arguing that we should offer up a living sacrifice. And not just anyone—two heroes who’ve done more for us than anyone else.”

“Sky and Jin are heroes who’ll be remembered throughout human history. I’m grateful for their sacrifices, too.”

“If that’s true, then shut your damn mouth and go home right now. Hug your family, one by one. Then go to your study and take out the pistol you’ve hidden there. No need to bother writing a will. Everyone watching this broadcast, myself included, knows why you need to die.”

“My, how rude. I’m simply saying I expect those two to choose a noble sacrifice of their own accord, as great heroes would, for the sake of billions of people—”

“Fine. Then I have no choice.”

“What?”

“Go to hell, you son of a bitch.”

Bang! Bang-bang!

“Aaah!”

“Fuck! Healer! Get a healer in here, now!”

“Doctor, calm down and put the gun down! This is a warn—”

BEEEEEP!

“We apologize for the unfortunate incident during our live broadcast. We will do everything we can to resolve the situation—”

Beep.

At last, silence settled over the room. The Skeleton King stared without a word at the holographic TV, now giving off only a dim glow. Then he spoke.

“Humans.”

His voice was thick with unconcealed disgust. Chuck Hagel, who had been staring at the whiskey bottle on the table, answered him.

“As a human, I have to say, that’s a weird thing to listen to.”

“Why don’t you try arguing against it, then?”

“I’m not going to. He wasn’t wrong. Especially that last guy. He deserved to get shot.”

The Skeleton King nodded.

Even he thought the old doctor, the foremost scholar on the Great Cataclysm and magical power, had handled the situation admirably.

The man looked to be in his nineties and, far from being Awakened, seemed to need a shot of stimulants just to move. But America’s venerable martial art of gun-fu had no age limit.

“Do you think he survived?”

“He wasn’t hit in the head, so probably.”

“Pity.”

“I agree completely. But it’s better for that guy to stay alive. If he died there, it could actually hurt public opinion.”

“…Fair enough.”

In the silence that followed, the Skeleton King replayed the scenes he’d seen on TV.

Anxiety and fear boiling over everywhere.

The magical power distribution soaring toward the levels of the Great Cataclysm—and the nonsense now being broadcast openly across the world.

Things were happening everywhere that the Skeleton King simply couldn't understand.

"You human, steeped in alcohol and tobacco. May I ask you something?"

"I quit drinking and smoking a few hours ago, but go ahead."

"What is the essence of humanity?"

"That's a difficult question. Philosophy isn't really my field."

"I already know you're not particularly intelligent, so don't worry."

"…Fine."

Chuck Hagel glared at the Skeleton King, then shrugged.

"All of it."

"All of it?"

"Yeah. Everything you've seen and felt while you've been with us. That's what I think, anyway."

"Humans are stupid enough to make me want to crack open their skulls and examine their brains, and so greedy and cowardly it's hard to believe. That's their essence?"

"I wish I could deny it, but that's part of it, too. It isn't all you've seen, though, is it?"

Of course it wasn't.

If all the Skeleton King had ever seen were those ugly sides of humanity, he never would have lived among them in human form.

He liked humans.

He'd always felt different from ordinary monsters. Ever since he'd met a human in the dark forest inside a Gate, he'd stayed with them.

But…

"Even so, this… This shouldn't be possible."

"Listen, my bony friend. There's no such thing as impossible."

Chuck Hagel ran his fingers over the whiskey bottle, still unopened after several hours, as if testing the limits of his own patience. Then he added:

"Things that should never happen are happening anyway."

"Then…"

"Right. More people will start agreeing with that damn 'noble sacrifice' the guy who just got shot was talking about. Humanity's running out of time, but it has a choice."

"Even if humans have an evil side, they'd offer up the heroes who risked their lives fighting for them?"

"Offer them up? What are you talking about?"

"…?"

“I said ‘sacrifice.‘ That’s what they really want. To look away without getting their hands dirty or taking the blame. To leave the people they’d sacrifice with no choice but to decide for themselves.”

“…!”

“The biggest problem is that Jin is exactly the kind of person who’d do it.”

For a moment, the Skeleton King bit down on his lip without realizing it.

Chuck was right.

That was the kind of human Jin Taekyung was.

He was always scolding and teasing the Skeleton King, but he carried a heavier burden than anyone else in the world.

And that made the Skeleton King more anxious than ever.

If the world wanted him dead, Jin Taekyung was exactly the sort of person who would sacrifice himself.

“That’s ridiculous. Even if that treacherous human… even if Jin Taekyung sacrificed himself alongside Sky, how could we be sure Morgoth would keep his promise?”

“Humans see what they want to see and believe what they want to believe. Morgoth knows that all too well.”

It was true.

As the news had just reported, Morgoth had kept his promise.

He’d left the governments of the twenty-odd countries that had declared their surrender in place, Russia among them, and completely stopped his monsters from killing people.

And that had given people hope.

Hope that Morgoth was different from the Demon King Asmodeus.

Hope that, even if they could no longer enjoy the freedom they’d had before, countless lives could be saved.

“But the chance that Morgoth will kill those two and break his promise…”

“Is overwhelmingly high. There’s no question about it. At least, we know that with absolute certainty. But do you think people, half-crazed with fear, are going to think that way?”

Chuck Hagel continued, his voice growing rougher.

“By the time those bastards realize their mistake, it’ll be too late. The only Hunter who can fight Morgoth right now will be inside that bastard’s stomach.”

As Chuck’s voice rang with pent-up anger, a thought suddenly flashed through the Skeleton King’s mind.

Chapter 1156

At the moment the Skeleton King thought of something during his conversation with Chuck Hagel, the man they were talking about stood alone in the deepest, most secret chamber of the heavily guarded Pentagon.

Or perhaps “alone” wasn’t quite right.

Strictly speaking, Jin Taekyung wasn’t alone.

“I should’ve come to see you more often. Circumstances kept me away.”

He looked slowly around the vast white space. It was as bright as if hundreds of lights were shining at once, and so empty it felt hollow.

“I heard you moved recently. I didn’t know it was to a place like this.”

He truly hadn’t. The moment he stepped inside, he’d been startled by the resemblance.

It looked so much like the mysterious space he called the Inventory, where he’d had an encounter he never could have expected.

“Just a coincidence, I’m sure. Probably.”

It had to be. The massive Grand Mage who had painstakingly designed this secret space for one person didn’t even know the Inventory existed, much less what it looked like.

But…

“Honestly, I don’t know what to believe anymore. I’m not even sure what I know, or what’s true and what’s false.”

At some point, everything he’d taken for granted had begun to fall apart. Faced with a reality beyond comprehension, his reason had grown hazy, and instinct had filled the void.

An uncertain instinct, closer to a wild guess—one even Jin Taekyung could hardly make sense of.

And now, reflected in his eyes, was the person who might well be the beginning and end of it all.

“Can you hear me? Can you see me?”

Jin Taekyung lowered his gaze.

Before him stood an oval recovery capsule connected to countless Magic Formations and machines. Inside that coffin for the living lay an old man, sunk in a sleep from which no one could wake him.

“If you can, please answer me.”

Of course, Jin Taekyung knew no answer would come, no matter how many times he asked or how long he waited.

Even so, he had to ask.

“Are you the person I think you are?”

The greatest hero humanity had ever produced.

His real name was Cheon Taemin. His titles were Slayer and Sky.

And…

"The Martial God."

Jin Taekyung let out the breath he'd been holding.

Through the translucent membrane fogged by his warm breath, he stared at Cheon Taemin's peaceful, sleeping face.

"I could feel it. The person I met back then, in that place… was you. I'm sure of it."

Hiss. Crackle!

His voice had grown louder without him noticing, echoing through the space. His hand, tensing on its own, struck the countless protective spells surrounding the capsule. But Jin Taekyung paid no mind to the pain in his skin.

He needed an answer to the conviction he'd only recently arrived at, incomplete though it was.

He needed to confirm that Cheon Taemin and the old man he called The Helper were the same person. That Cheon Taemin, too, had been a Player like him. And he needed to know how things had come to this.

More than anything—

"Why? Why won't you wake up?"

No matter how hard he tried to hold it back, the anger in his chest kept boiling over. He needed somewhere to let it out.

"…Why?"

Why do I, who fall so far short of you, have to bear this burden?

At that moment—

Hiss.

Unable to speak the thought aloud, Jin Taekyung pulled his hand from the capsule.

Then he turned and blurted, "What, I thought it was one visitor at a time?"

His surging emotions weren't the only reason he'd stopped speaking. A second visitor had just arrived.

"As far as I know, there's no such rule. And even if there were, family ought to be an exception."

"Wow. When you put it like that, what can I say?"

"For the record, I only just got here."

"They say a guilty conscience needs no accuser. Who said anything?"

Jin Taekyung's expression and tone were as playful as ever, at odds with how he'd been only moments before.

Team Leader Choi—Choi Minwoo—watched him for a moment, then shrugged.

"I should have knocked. Not that it would have made a sound through the barrier magic."

“You didn’t have to go that far.”

“I suddenly thought of my grandfather and went looking for Mr. Johnson. I heard he’d already brought you here. I’m sorry if I intruded.”

“Don’t be. If anything, I’m the one intruding.”

Jin Taekyung smiled and waved a hand as he started walking.

“May I ask why you came to see my grandfather?”

After a moment’s silence, Jin Taekyung gave a short laugh.

“What, worried something might happen?”

In a situation like this, there was only one thing to worry about: Jin Taekyung taking Cheon Taemin to the Dragon Lair, just the two of them.

Of course, Cheon Taemin had been unconscious for a long time, and nobody in the Pentagon wanted that to happen. If it did, it would effectively be Jin Taekyung acting on his own.

But while Jin Taekyung’s question had sounded like a joke, Choi Minwoo’s answer came in a low, steady voice.

“Yes.”

“…!”

“To be honest, I’m very worried.”

Before Jin Taekyung could answer, eyes widening, Choi Minwoo added calmly, “I’m worried that you, Mr. Jin Taekyung, might make the stupid choice of fighting Morgoth alone.”

“…”

“Answer me, please. Deny it if you want.”

Jin Taekyung stared at him in silence, then spoke.

“Fine. Let me make this perfectly clear. I would never do that.”

“I see.”

“Yeah. So that settles it, right?”

“No.”

“What? Why not?”

“Because I don’t believe you at all.”

“…!”

“Anyone who knows you well would feel the same. Spend enough time around you, and it becomes obvious how recklessly and foolishly you choose to act.”

Choi Minwoo stepped closer and looked at his grandfather sleeping inside the recovery capsule.

“My maternal grandfather must have been the same. The two of you are so alike.”

“Alike?”

“Yes. Realizing that has brought me a little comfort. Only very recently, in fact.”

“What do you mean…?”

“Even after you came back from the Middle East, you haven’t gone to see your family. Even though you’re staying right here in the Pentagon.”

Family.

At that one word, Jin Taekyung’s eyes trembled.

His mother and younger sister. His family by blood, more precious to him than anything else in the world, had been under the Pentagon’s protection for quite some time.

But he hadn’t gone to see them once.

No. He couldn’t see them.

If he did, the invisible pillar barely holding him up would collapse. And if he crumbled now, he wouldn’t be able to summon even the smallest shred of courage.

“You’ve refused to meet the other Guild members, too. I’m sure it’s for the same reason.”

Jin Taekyung had come to know countless Hunters, but there were only two people left whom he and Choi Minwoo could call Guild members.

Song Song and Im Kkeokjeong.

Jin Taekyung had avoided them, too.

The path ahead of him was riddled with danger. Death came for everyone, but it didn’t come for everyone at the same speed.

What would happen if those two joined the battle to come, when neither was an S-rank Hunter or a Supreme Peak master?

They’d die. Without a doubt.

This was a colossal gamble with the lives of billions at stake, not just his own. In a world without the Three Saints or the Fire King, he couldn’t bear the weight he alone had to carry.

So he ran.

From his family. From his friends.

He’d fled everyone around him and come here, wanting to face Cheon Taemin once more, even like this. The only person who could understand him. The person who might hold the answer—and the key—to everything.

Then Choi Minwoo’s next words reached him, and Jin Taekyung realized something.

“Watching you, Mr. Jin Taekyung, finally made me understand how my grandfather felt when he never came to see his only grandson.”

Something he’d failed to notice until now.

“Maybe I just want to find a reason for it. But… I’ve decided to think that he had no choice but to keep me at a distance because of some danger only he could sense.”

Choi Minwoo's voice held a bitter smile. And in his words was a meaning even he hadn't noticed.

Some danger only he could sense?

That couldn't be. At the time, there had been no danger left for humanity.

The once-mighty Demon King Asmodeus had been reduced to dust, without even a body left behind. The monster legions that had stained the Five Oceans and Six Continents with blood had become nothing more than prey.

Yet as soon as peace arrived, the hero who had achieved that great feat shut himself away from the world.

He kept everyone at a distance.

No one was an exception.

Not even his closest companions, practically sworn brothers, or the daughter he'd cherished above all else.

When that daughter and her husband died in an accident, he left his young grandson in Butler Kim's care rather than look after the boy himself.

Then, one day, without warning, he lost consciousness.

And remained unconscious for more than a decade.

…Were you that afraid, too?

With those words swallowed on the tip of his tongue, Jin Taekyung gazed at Cheon Taemin, his eyes sinking into darkness.

He'd been right.

He still had no definite proof or testimony, but Choi Minwoo's words had made him see it again: Cheon Taemin and the Martial God had been the same person all along.

The shadow of that old hero, sleeping as if dead, stretched across two worlds.

He knew. He knew it wasn't over yet. That Asmodeus hadn't been completely erased.

There was still so much Jin Taekyung hadn't uncovered, so much he wanted to ask.

But this was enough.

At least he now knew what choice he had to make.

Step.

He turned without hesitation and started walking.

He'd taken only a few steps when he noticed a tiny but important change and stopped.

The door.

It was gone.

The only exit from this secret space, created through advanced magic, had vanished without a trace.

"Team Leader."

At his quiet call, Jin Taekyung turned. Choi Minwoo stood there, his expression unwavering.

“I’m sorry.”

The brief, calm apology told Jin Taekyung everything.

“Was this your plan from the beginning?”

“As I said earlier, we know exactly what kind of person you are, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“We?”

“Of course, this wasn’t a decision I made on my own. Most of them, including Mr. Johnson and me, have already agreed to the plan.”

“Most? Then someone must have opposed this ridiculous plan.”

“No. No one did. We didn’t tell the people who might have caused trouble from the start, in case they became an unexpected variable. We’ve also made every other preparation we can.”

Thinking of Chuck Hagel and the Skeleton King, who still knew nothing about it, Choi Minwoo continued in a composed voice.

“So… for the time we have left, you’ll stay here with me, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

The many people involved in the plan had a single goal: use every means at their disposal to keep Jin Taekyung—their only hope—here until the three days Morgoth had declared to the world were over.

Fortunately, the secret space Jin Taekyung had found was perfectly suited to carry out the plan. Countless barrier spells had been installed to protect Cheon Taemin.

Even so, one unpredictable element remained: Jin Taekyung himself.

The savior of a new age.

The greatest and strongest Hunter in the world, successor to Cheon Taemin—a man no one else could replace.

That was precisely why they couldn’t let him sacrifice himself in vain. And Choi Minwoo hadn’t forgotten one final precaution.

“No matter how strong you are, Mr. Jin Taekyung, you won’t be able to get out of here.”

“Is that so?”

Jin Taekyung reached into the air. A silver spear, invisible until now, appeared in his grasp.

Whoosh.

Dark blue flames surged along White Flame’s spearhead. The fire was refined to an extraordinary degree and carried heat beyond anything Choi Minwoo had felt from it the last time he’d seen it.

But Choi Minwoo didn’t waver.

“Come to think of it, there’s one thing I haven’t told you.”

The final precaution he'd taken was never meant to counter Jin Taekyung's strength.

"If you try to break the barrier spells by force, the resulting backlash could bring down the entire Pentagon."

At least, Choi Minwoo didn't waver until he heard Jin Taekyung's answer.

"You really think so?"

Grgrgrk.

As the space warped beneath the unbearable heat, Jin Taekyung's quiet voice echoed through it like a distant refrain.

"I think otherwise."

"…!"

Choi Minwoo's eyes widened.

Slice.

Along a seam only one person could see, the vast wave of mana that joined and sustained hundreds of spells split in two.

Chapter 1157

The spearhead, wreathed in dark blue flames, rose as if to pierce the ceiling. Choi Minwoo wasn't the only one whose eyes went wide.

"…!"

There wasn't even time to utter a curse.

Magic Johnson stared in shock at Jin Taekyung's unexpected move. He'd designed this secret space himself, and he'd been watching what happened inside it with a heavy heart. Now he felt as if even the hair he didn't have was standing on end.

No way. Surely not.

He swallowed hard.

Why was he so tense?

Simple. If the magic was forcibly broken, the backlash would batter him—the caster—before it ever shook the Pentagon.

No. Maybe…

I could die.

To a mage, mana was another sense beyond the five, as much a part of the body as flesh and bone. When a spell cast with a mage's own mana was forcibly dispelled, the mage suffered a worse blow than anyone else.

Magic Johnson knew that better than most. He'd only done something as insane as packing hundreds of security and barrier spells into the space because he trusted Jin Taekyung.

He trusted that the Jin Taekyung he knew would never hurt him.

But at that very moment—

Whoosh!

The spearhead swept down without hesitation, mercilessly cutting through the last shred of his trust.

"Fuuuck—!"

Johnson squeezed his eyes shut and finally let out the curse he'd been holding back.

The mana links connecting him to countless spells snapped. He felt the onset of a backlash powerful enough to kill him.

A warm breeze blew past.

…Wait. A breeze?

He heard nothing. Felt nothing. No earthshaking roar, no tremendous force rocking everything around him.

Only energy drifting away like sea fog in the sun.

His eyelids twitched. Unable to make sense of it, the massive Grand Mage finally gathered the courage to open his eyes.

Someone was standing in front of him. Johnson stared blankly for a moment, then spoke as if he'd made up his mind.

"Jin, be honest with me."

Jin Taekyung straightened his spear. "Go ahead."

"Did I die and go to heaven?"

"Whether you're dead is another question, but isn't this place a little bleak for heaven? We can't even see the sky."

"Everything's hazy. Like we're at the top of Mount Everest."

"That's water vapor, not clouds."

"Damn, you're right. Then if it's not heaven, is this a dream?"

"I hope not."

"Why?"

"If I'm showing up even in your dreams, maybe I'm your type."

"Oh, dear. I hadn't thought of that."

Johnson gave a bitter smile.

"All right. So it's come to this."

Jin Taekyung nodded calmly. "Looks like it."

"I'm truly sorry. I didn't want to go this far."

"I understand. I'm not just saying that. I really do."

"Thanks. I think our friend over there feels the same way."

Right on cue, Choi Minwoo emerged through the thick steam and studied Jin Taekyung with a complicated expression.

"You've gotten stronger. Even stronger than the last time I saw you."

In Choi Minwoo's memory, Jin Taekyung had always been strong. Even on their first raid, when Jin had gone along as a mere porter rather than a combatant. He'd gone on to surpass Choi Minwoo's expectations by a staggering margin, again and again.

Today was no different. And that pained Choi Minwoo.

"To be honest… I don't know whether I should be happy that you've gotten stronger again, or sad."

Choi Minwoo had often thought about that famous line from a superhero movie that was now a classic: *With great power comes great responsibility.* Sometimes it seemed as though it had been written for Jin Taekyung.

To Choi Minwoo, Jin Taekyung seemed as vulnerable as he was strong. The stronger he became, the greater the threats he tried to face alone.

But Jin Taekyung's reply was light and cheerful, nothing like Choi Minwoo's words.

"Better to be happy, if you ask me."

"Is that so?"

"That's what I'd prefer. There's always plenty to be sad about anyway."

"If you died, what would I do then?"

"What kind of question is that?"

Jin Taekyung gave a short laugh.

"Be sad when it happens. As much as you want."

"…!"

"Let's not worry about something that hasn't happened yet. I'm not exactly qualified to give you advice on that, Team Leader. I'm bad at it myself… But after going through it, I think that's the right way."

Choi Minwoo blinked.

He was different. Maybe Choi Minwoo was imagining it, but the change was unmistakable. Barely ten minutes ago, Jin Taekyung had been forcing a smile. Now his smile was genuinely at ease.

Like someone who'd set down a heavy burden.

Only Jin Taekyung knew why.

If I died…

Death.

Jin Taekyung turned that sticky, dark word over in his mind.

Of course he was afraid of dying. He'd been afraid every day, every moment. But today, he'd finally understood something clearly.

What he truly feared wasn't death itself. It was what would happen after he died.

The danger the people he left behind would face.

But this is enough.

Jin Taekyung didn't turn around, but all five of his senses were trained on the person now far behind him.

Cheon Taemin.

Another Player—someone he'd once thought couldn't possibly exist.

Even if I really do die, maybe then…

He swallowed the rest of the words on the tip of his tongue and looked squarely at his two close friends and trusted comrades.

"As the Alliance Leader of the World Hunter Federation, I'm issuing a full mobilization order, effective immediately. Destination: Moscow. Objective: annihilate Morgoth and the monsters under his command."

"…!"

"…!"

Their eyes widened. Jin Taekyung added firmly, "But no one is to do anything rash until I give further orders. Unless I'm unable to issue them, of course."

"Right. Good thinking. We'll all fight together—wait. What do you mean, 'unless you're unable to issue them'?"

Johnson had only just realized something was wrong when Jin Taekyung spoke again.

"I mean if my position becomes vacant."

Neither man could miss what that meant. Choi Minwoo bit his lip, and Johnson let out a low groan.

"Damn it, Jin."

"Nothing you say will change my mind. I'm going to Morgoth. Right now. Alone."

"…Are you sure that's the best option? You're really going to bet your life on a crazy gamble with less than a one-percent chance of winning?"

"Yes."

There wasn't a trace of hesitation or doubt in his voice or eyes.

For a moment, Johnson was at a loss for words.

But then, suddenly, he remembered someone from decades ago. When everyone had been thrown into utter confusion, that person alone had stepped forward and led the way.

A hero who'd made himself a beacon and lit up the world.

Sky.

Yes. Him.

And now another Cheon Taemin stood before Johnson.

No—Jin Taekyung.

"…Ha."

A sigh slipped through Johnson's clenched teeth.

At last, he had to accept what Jin Taekyung had told him: no argument would change his mind. He had to accept the role left to them, too.

"Fine, Jin. Go on and tell us your plan. Say whatever you want. But first, there's something I have to say."

The massive Grand Mage took a deep breath, then addressed the savior of a new age.

"Whatever happens, don't you dare die. Not unless you want me to beat you to death with my staff."

Jin Taekyung gave a rueful laugh. "That's the plan. I'd rather not die twice."

A little while later, the two men had heard him out and fallen silent.

Wheeeee!

A siren, as jarring as what they'd just heard, shook the depths beneath the Pentagon. An operator's urgent voice blared through the magical equipment.

"Code Red! Code Red!"

"Code Red?"

"It's an emergency. The highest alert level. What happened all of a sudden?"

“Unauthorized use of magic detected!”

“Security forces, deploy immediately to Area 52! Repeat: security forces, deploy immediately to Area 52!”

“Area 52… That’s where the transport Magic Formation is.”

“You mean the Warp magic?”

“Yeah. But access to the entire Pentagon has been forbidden for a week now. Is an inside collaborator we don’t know about trying to escape because they think they’re about to be found out?”

It wasn’t an unreasonable guess. Most of those who had surrendered to Morgoth had bowed to him to survive, but some were actively cooperating with him.

In Africa, rebel holdouts that hadn’t been completely rooted out in the previous incident were rampaging. In South America, drug cartels were running wild, more ferocious than the monsters.

By ordinary standards, Johnson’s guess made sense.

“Emergency! Code Name Blue! Code Name Blue has escaped through Area 52!”

The operator was nearly panting now. All three men fell silent, though for different reasons.

Jin Taekyung had no idea what the announcement meant.

The other two knew all too well.

In the end, Jin Taekyung was the first to break the silence. He couldn’t take them staring at him any longer.

“Okay. I get that I’m an idiot, so cut it out and tell me what Code Name Blue is.”

Choi Minwoo blinked. “Uh, well. Of course you wouldn’t know, Mr. Jin Taekyung.”

“Why?”

“Because it’s a secret from you.”

Magic Johnson looked back and forth between Jin Taekyung, who had no idea what was going on, and the magical equipment installed in a corner of the underground corridor.

“It’s you, Jin.”

“What? Where did that come from—”

“Code Name Blue. The one they just mentioned. That’s you.”

“…What?”

Jin Taekyung needed a moment to make sense of that.

“So they’re saying I just left the Pentagon without permission?”

“Well, to be precise…”

Someone who would do such a thing had already come to Johnson’s mind.

“Someone who looks like you.”

They hurried to the surface. The first person they ran into was—

“Goddamn it. Where the hell were all of you, leaving me on my own in a situation like this?”

Chuck Hagel, who had somehow ended up on his own.

Chapter 1158

It was a ruin.

A complete ruin. No other words were needed.

But the man who had appeared in a sudden flash of light barely ten seconds ago saw it a little differently.

A grave.

That was the first thought that came to him.

He could feel it the moment he looked around—no, even before he opened his eyes. Death saturated the air like thick fog at dawn. From every corner of this enormous grave, where the clouds overhead shut out every ray of light, rose the screams of countless vengeful spirits.

"…I suppose so."

The man muttered bitterly, then kicked off the ground and shot forward.

Fwoooosh!

Perhaps it was the magical power swirling in his wake as he streaked forward like an arrow. The spirits reacted to it, stopped screaming, and began following him one by one.

"Don't follow me. I'm not your enemy."

Whoooom.

Beyond the howl of the wind, the man heard the spirits' answer and nodded.

"Yeah. I'm going there."

Whooom—

"If that's what you really want… Fine, I'll allow it. Having you along for a little while wouldn't be so bad."

If an ordinary person had seen this, they would surely have been surprised by two things.

First, the man was behaving like a lunatic.

Second, this lunatic was someone the whole world knew.

But the spirits were different. Just as the man could sense their presence and hear their voices, they could see him as he truly was.

They were different kinds of beings, certainly, but death linked them.

"I know. It's unfair. I'm sorry I couldn't save you."

The man went on as if talking to himself.

"Of course not. You did nothing wrong. It was just a misfortune, the kind that could happen to anyone."

"You're asking whether God or heaven really exists? Why?"

“…Your child, huh? I see. But don’t worry. A child that young would have gone to heaven. No, I’m sure of it.”

“I don’t know what God looks like. It was so long ago that my memory’s a little hazy.”

“You there. Take that back. I am a great being, far beyond the likes of you. My memory’s just a little bad, that’s all.”

“Yeah, damn it. You’re right. I don’t remember a thing. But ever since I started traveling with a strange fellow, I sometimes get déjà vu. Like I’ve been through something similar several times before.”

“I’ve given it some serious thought, and I think I must have been human once, too. An incredibly noble and admirable human, just like I am now—damn it. Everyone, quiet down. I’m trying to say something important.”

“Oh, don’t cry. I wasn’t talking to you. How old are you? Where are your parents?”

“…All right. I can’t promise anything, but if I find your parents, I’ll make sure you see them.”

The man continued forward, talking with the spirits as he went.

A young man who had only just taken his first steps into adulthood. An old man who had accepted his death and wanted to know about the afterlife. Parents who had lost a child, and a child who had lost their parents.

The scenery changed in an instant, but the spirits never stopped whispering. They were indignant and furious at the death that had struck without warning, grieving even as they trembled with fear.

And the man never once turned away from their voices.

Because he was their king.

He alone had the right and the duty to guide those who had lost everything in an instant and now wandered the Nine Springs[3913]—those who had become his people.

But perhaps the spirits weren’t the only ones finding comfort and peace in this strange conversation.

“Why did I come here? Hmm, excellent question. This is an epic tale that begins with the most handsome and admirable hero in the world.”

The man leaped over the ruins in his path and continued.

“The hero had many talents. He was incredibly strong and had a noble heart. But despite all that, he was surrounded by idiots and incompetents. Then one day, he learned that the biggest fool of them all was in trouble.”

But the hero knew the surest way to help the fool. It was something only he could do.

Because he was a hero.

[3913]The Nine Springs is an East Asian expression for the realm of the dead.

“While the hero was deep in thought, some ignorant bastard who was crazy about booze and cigarettes told him that people see what they want to see and believe what they want to believe. So the hero decided to borrow the fool’s appearance for a while.”

It hadn’t been all that difficult. As he’d said, the hero was unbelievably talented, and his greatest ability was “absorption.”

“Actually, I didn’t know I could do that. No, the hero didn’t. But when he tried it, it worked. It wasn’t nearly as good as the Doppelganger’s own ability, though.”

Was it because of his innate ability to grow stronger by absorbing the magical power of monsters that had been destroyed? Or was it because his magical power levels had already reached the point of going berserk?

Amazingly, the hero, who wasn’t human, had gained a new power he’d never discovered before. After traveling thousands of kilometers[3914] by way of several Warp Gates, he had made it here.

Of course, there had been some trouble along the way.

He’d threatened the mages who refused to activate the Warp Gate. Or he’d taken a selfie in his current appearance, posted it on social media, and deliberately spread the word far and wide.

But none of those little things mattered to the man.

The crowning touch of his story was still to come.

“Most of you figured it out from the start, didn’t you? Yes, that’s right. I am that hero.”

Fwoosh.

Silence fell. The man blinked, his solemn declaration still hanging in the air.

“Why is everyone so quiet? You’d think you were dead. Oh, right. You are dead.”

“What? You didn’t see it coming? That’s impossible. The foreshadowing was perfect from the start. I said I was the most handsome and excellent man in the world—damn it. Forget it. You stupid humans.”

That was when the grumbling man suddenly stopped walking.

“…I’m here already?”

He murmured and looked at the scenery, now completely transformed.

As if someone had drawn a line across the world, pitch-black earth lay only a few steps ahead, starkly different from the ground behind him.

Whooom. Whooooooom—

At the same time, the countless spirits surrounding him began to scream.

Screams filled with a terror unlike anything they had shown before.

“Don’t be so afraid. Weak spirits like you would have a hard time entering that place anyway. Not that I was planning to take you with me in the first place.”

[3914] Thousands of kilometers is roughly thousands of miles; 2,000–9,000 km is about 1,200–5,600 mi.

But the man was different.

While the spirits writhed as if burned by fire, he knew he would grow stronger the closer he came to that ominous, pitch-black earth.

After all, the only thing I can fake is my appearance.

The thought faded hollowly in his mind as he drew the sword tucked at his waist.

Shing.

Its blade was clear as untainted ice.

The man silently gazed at his reflection.

Or rather, at the face of the person who was probably chasing him as fast as he could somewhere out there.

“You’re a step too late this time, you wily human bastard.”

The man—the Skeleton King—snickered. Someone reflected in the blade snickered along with him.

“Yeah, keep smiling like that. Don’t scowl with that ugly face of yours.”

He meant it.

That fool—Jin Taekyung—deserved to smile.

“Then, here I go.”

With a final farewell that would never reach him, the Skeleton King took a firm step forward.

Using the light spilling from his sword as a torch, he headed for the land of death, where magical power churned, and thought:

Sacrifice, huh? This isn’t so bad.

Even if he died, he wouldn’t regret it.

Once he met a glorious end in the form of Jin Taekyung—not the Skeleton King or the Stone-King—all of humanity would understand.

They would see how foolish they had been to believe the monster’s promise to stop the destruction and slaughter if they handed over Jin Taekyung.

And they would understand the only way to escape this catastrophe.

Fwoooosh.

The dense fog drifting over the pitch-black earth swallowed his retreating figure.

Morgoth recalled an old saying he’d heard long ago: Sometimes, a certain kind of curiosity can shorten a person’s life.

He’d first heard it while living among humans, and it had fascinated him.

Unlike humans, Dragons couldn’t live long without curiosity. Morgoth himself was a prime example.

He had always been curious.

Ever since he was no more than a Hatchling—before he'd even broken out of his egg.

Perhaps that was why Morgoth had become unlike other Dragons.

His curiosity would not rest until he had reached the highest level of whatever caught his interest.

Humans, Dwarves, Elves, and other races besides—driven solely by curiosity, he had spent ages among them, learning and giving in turn, and ruling over them as well.

No matter how often he changed his appearance or where he went, Morgoth was a born ruler.

His election as Dragon Lord before he was even a thousand years old was proof.

The pride of his race and the king of the world.

He was more complete and absolute than anyone.

At least, he would have been, if not for the one curiosity he had never been able to satisfy.

The Demon Realm.

The home of all monsters. A land of demons where poison, corpses, and death flowed instead of clear river water.

His curiosity about the unknown deepened with every passing day, until Morgoth took his first step into that forbidden realm.

Yes. That was where it all began.

But why? Even after an extraordinarily long time, the curiosity filling Morgoth's heart had not faded.

And among his unanswered questions was one that, as the human saying went, might truly shorten his life.

Asmodeus, why did you choose me of all people?

Morgoth possessed knowledge and power beyond measure, yet he did not know why he had come to this world.

One day, a call had reached him from beyond those distant stars and the space between them, and he had answered it. That was all.

Which made it even harder to understand.

Unlike the others, he was neither devoted to serving Demon King Asmodeus nor willing to give his life for him.

Besides, how could you, when you don't even exist in this world, have prepared a stage like this?

But Morgoth did not pursue these questions further.

No. More precisely, he had to set them aside for now.

The guest he had truly wanted to meet had just arrived at his palace.

"Come in, hero."

Morgoth rose from his throne and welcomed his first guest with delight.

Chapter 1159

Boom. Rumble, rumble.

As the iron doors opened with a heavy roar, the Skeleton King had a sudden thought.

If he'd really been human, he might have mistaken the sound for his own heartbeat.

But even without a heart, he could feel it clearly.

With every step he took, the distance narrowed. With every iron door that opened in turn, the immense magical power ahead of him swelled.

And at the end of it all, the being at the source of everything waited for him.

"Come in, hero."

The last door opened at the sound of a low voice, and the Skeleton King swallowed without meaning to.

This is…

Until now, his eyes had held nothing but darkness. Now they were filled with dazzling light.

Was this what it would look like if someone brought a palace from the myths of old gods into the world?

The chamber was hundreds of meters[3915] across, filled with antique furniture that had endured the ages and jewels of every color. Countless images were engraved into its towering ceiling and the walls on every side.

Beautiful.

No—more than beautiful. Astonishing.

Yet even amid that dazzling sight, the Skeleton King looked in only one direction.

At a being more beautiful than everything in the chamber combined, no matter how many times you added it up or multiplied it—and possessed of a power more terrifying than anything else in the world.

"You seem to like the place. Good."

The palace's master smiled as he drifted gently down from the throne towering in the distance, as if he'd spread invisible wings.

"I don't need to introduce myself, do I?"

He certainly didn't.

The Skeleton King knew who he was. So did all of humanity.

"…Morgoth."

The name escaped the Skeleton King like a groan. Morgoth smiled and nodded.

[3915] 100 meters is about 328 ft (109 yd); "hundreds of meters" does not specify an exact distance.

“So you do know me. Still, it wouldn’t hurt to formally exchange names, as is the custom in this world.”

The Skeleton King understood what he meant and replied, thinking once more of the one person who wasn’t here—and shouldn’t be.

“Jin Taekyung. Jin Taekyung.”

“I see. Jin Taekyung…”

Morgoth seemed to mull it over.

“No matter how many times I hear it, it’s a strange name. Does it have some special meaning?”

“Of course it does.”

The Skeleton King shrugged, then gave an answer so perfectly suited to Jin Taekyung that, had the real Jin Taekyung been there, he might have mistaken him for a Doppelganger.

“It means ‘fuck you.‘”

Morgoth stared at him, momentarily dumbfounded, then burst out laughing.

“Well, you got me. That’s rather funny.”

“Get all your laughing out now. After you’ve taken a few hits in a minute, you won’t find it so funny.”

The Skeleton King made no effort to hide his hostility.

The moment he’d faced Morgoth, he’d realized that a surprise attack meant to catch him off guard would never work.

How is this possible?

He’d never felt so overwhelmed just by standing before someone.

Strictly speaking, he’d felt something similar once, back when he was called the Skeleton Warlord and fought Jin Taekyung. But there was no comparing the two.

Just as the Jin Taekyung of then couldn’t be compared to the Jin Taekyung of now, the Skeleton King had grown at a terrifying pace, too.

If anything, his rate of growth might even have surpassed Jin Taekyung’s.

Since joining Jin Taekyung, he’d defeated one Named Monster after another, starting with the Arch Lich, and absorbed their vast magical power like nourishment.

He’d become so powerful that the title of king no longer seemed inadequate.

But…

We’re on different levels.

Undead: a cursed being.

A Dragon: a being born with the blessing of all creation.

The two faced each other at eye level, but everything else about them was different—their very natures, and the magnitude and depth of the power born of them.

So why did the Skeleton King feel more at ease as he gripped his sword hilt?

Even with Morgoth watching his every move, it felt as natural as folding his arms.

“Are you planning to fight me?”

“Why? Didn’t you expect it?”

“I did, from the moment you appeared alone. I only wanted to tell you it’s a poor choice.”

“There was never another choice.”

“Never another choice? I find it hard to understand why you think that.”

Morgoth tilted his head.

“I’ve lived for a very long time, and yet you’re a fascinating being. I’ve always had a weakness for exceptional talent.”

“So you’re telling me to surrender?”

“Become my Guardian. You’ll have the honor of protecting the true king at his side, and gain greater power and eternal life as well.”

“What an honor.”

“It’s an entirely reasonable and peaceful solution, too. What do you say?”

The Skeleton King gave a disbelieving laugh.

“Jin Taekyung.”

“What?”

“I told you what it means earlier.”

At that moment—

Shing.

A silver blade, its edge sharp as frost, finally emerged from its sheath.

“This is my answer.”

It was Jin Taekyung’s answer, too. The Skeleton King knew he would have done exactly the same.

Morgoth watched him and murmured, almost to himself, “How strange. I simply don’t understand.”

“What, are you that shocked I turned down your shitty offer?”

“I won’t deny that your foolish choice disappoints me. But that isn’t what I find so hard to understand.”

Rustle.

Morgoth’s obsidian eyes moved slowly over his opponent. More precisely, over the Skeleton King and the [Hero’s Sword] in his hand.

His next words sent a shiver through the Skeleton King.

“How can an Undead Monster like you wield an Ego Sword like that?”

“…!”

"Oh, forgive me if I've offended you. It's just that even I can't explain what I'm seeing. Do you have any idea why?"

The Skeleton King didn't answer.

He couldn't. It took everything he had just to steady himself against the shock that had struck through his whole body like a bolt of lightning.

He knew. He knew what I was.

Since when?

When he gave his name? Or when he drew a sword instead of the spear Jin Taekyung always used?

Or… had Morgoth known from the moment he first set foot on the pitch-black ground of his territory, leaving the spirits' pleas behind?

Damn it.

The Skeleton King clenched his teeth. He met the Black Dragon's eyes, which seemed to see through everything he was.

"You were playing with me. From beginning to end."

"Oh dear."

Morgoth let out a soft sigh.

"Don't let a misunderstanding upset you. Everything I've said was sincere. You truly are that special and fascinating. Even in thousands of years, I've encountered few cases like yours."

"Shut your mouth."

"How rude. But I'll forgive you. Unlike an inferior race, I won't let a moment's anger drive me to destroy something precious. My intelligence and curiosity won't allow it."

Morgoth wasn't the least bit shaken. If anything, he looked at the Skeleton King with even greater interest.

The old, cunning Dragon's eyes glittered like those of a child heading into the hills to collect insects.

Even as a silver blade charged with powerful energy came slashing down at him.

Fwoosh—CRASH!

Fierce wind clawed through the chamber, and the energy carried by the sword swallowed everything within a radius of a dozen or so meters.[3916]

It was a blow so fierce that even the Named Monsters who had once struck terror across the world would have faced death if it hit them directly.

But before the roar rang out, the Skeleton King knew.

The strike he'd poured all his strength into hadn't harmed so much as a hair on his enemy's head.

Rumble, rumble…

[3916] A dozen meters is about 39 ft.

Beyond the enormous tremor shaking the space, Morgoth had already moved to the towering throne in the distance. He brought his hands together in a heartfelt round of applause.

"Impressive. Truly impressive. Such immense magical power—and of so many different kinds."

"You…"

"Ah, yes. The Arch Lich, Leviathan, Behemoth. You absorbed their magical power. But your current appearance doesn't seem to be the work of magic… Have you ever met a being called a Doppelganger?"

For an instant, the Skeleton King felt his mind go cold.

Morgoth had seen through him.

Too quickly, and with such chilling accuracy.

Seeing the Skeleton King's face go rigid, Morgoth broke into a broad smile.

"So you have. You can absorb not only a target's magical power, but part of their abilities, too. Astonishing. Now I understand how a mere undead—a Skeleton, no less—came to possess such power."

"That mere undead might kill a Dragon here today."

"Is that a taunt?"

"No. I mean it. It's a lesson I learned from watching a certain lunatic of a human."

The Skeleton King spat the words out as he approached. Morgoth nodded.

"Yes, of course you might. Even the mighty Asmodeus was stopped by a mere human. But…"

He looked the Skeleton King straight in the eye.

"Just as you learned a lesson through Jin Taekyung, I also realized the most important thing when I heard the news."

Whoooom.

Space warped.

Incredibly powerful, pure magical power filled the chamber, taking the form of invisible blades.

"Asmodeus's greatest mistake was his arrogance."

"…!"

"I do not underestimate any of you."

At the moment the Skeleton King's eyes widened—

Fwoooosh!

A flash of black, deeper and darker than the night sky, shot toward his entire body.

Chapter 1160

Undead.

Beings who had met death but had not died; who could move, yet could not be called alive.

But even the undead were not immortal.

They simply met another kind of death: Erasure.

Erasure, huh.

As time slowed, the Skeleton King watched countless black flashes fill the space around him and murmured to himself.

A path he had not yet taken.

And yet, one he would have to walk in the end.

He quietly closed his eyes.

Of course, he knew. If he moved now, he could still avoid Erasure. If he struggled with every ounce of his strength, until the last fragment of his soul crumbled into ash, he might even leave a tiny sword wound on that terrifyingly powerful Ancient Dragon's body.

But it would be pointless. The gap in their power—the difference in their very being—was too vast for him to hope for anything more.

There's no turning this around. This body—no, Jin Taekyung—will fall here today. At the hands of a monster bent on destroying the world.

And word would spread soon. Everything moved fast in this world.

That was why he had drawn as much attention as possible on his way here in Jin Taekyung's form. By now, everyone around the world would be watching Moscow closely.

If that happens, I won't regret it.

But unlike the Skeleton King, the people would regret what they had done—and be furious.

At the sight of a hero driven by an unseen hand to willingly meet his end, they would finally realize their mistake. Then they would unite and fight.

Even if the whole truth came to light, hearts once set would not be easily swayed.

Yeah. That's enough.

But why?

Even after making that resolve and repeating it to himself countless times, why did his heart feel as heavy as lead?

The sound of space being crushed left his ears ringing. His eyes were shut tight, yet he could still see those faces and hear those voices. What were they?

And why—

KA-BOOOOM!

—hadn't a single one of those terrible black flashes touched him? That tremendous magical power had seemed capable of devouring both his body and the soul within it without a trace.

This is…

A sudden sense of déjà vu swept over him. The Skeleton King opened his eyes.

And saw him.

Far away, the Black Dragon leaned back at an angle against his throne, staring at him with eyes that gleamed strangely.

"Just as I thought. Was that your plan from the start?"

"…!"

"I suppose I should take back what I said earlier. It seems I underestimated all of you… No, I underestimated you."

The Skeleton King's reflection gleamed in eyes like pieces of obsidian.

The Ancient Dragon's heart, worn down little by little over thousands of years, was pounding fiercely now.

"Why didn't you dodge?"

The Skeleton King gritted his teeth. Morgoth's question made it clear he had seen through not only the Skeleton King's appearance, but the whole situation.

"Because I had to."

"…!"

Crack.

The armrest of the golden throne crumbled to dust.

But Morgoth was not angry at the Skeleton King for trying to deceive him.

He was trembling with rising excitement and joy.

Because you had to?

Yes. This was it.

If the Skeleton King had tried to fight back in any way, Morgoth would have erased him with all his power, without the slightest hesitation.

He had no intention of letting a moment's curiosity cost him the two prized catches he sought: Cheon Taemin and Jin Taekyung.

The Adversary who defeated the Demon King in a mere human body. And the one who leads the world after him.

Those two alone had been Morgoth's greatest purpose and reason for coming to this world.

At least, until a moment ago.

But what the Skeleton King had just shown him was enough to shake him to the core.

A cursed undead monster, with a soul like this.

Everyone wanted to live. Humans and monsters alike.

But sacrifice was different.

Morgoth had spent vast stretches of time among many races in the name of amusement. Yet even the Elves of the forest, supposedly the noblest of them all, had never astonished him like this.

No. There was no point in comparing them.

Just as Morgoth had been born to rule the world, they had been born with pure hearts.

But the Skeleton King was unmistakably an undead monster. A being corrupted by an inescapable curse.

And yet he had tried to sacrifice himself—an undead monster who should have been made of nothing but rage and fear.

Though he feared Erasure and had the power to delay his end, if only for a little while, he had refused to retreat.

How is this possible?

It was like discovering an entirely new species.

Morgoth had chosen to become an evil Dragon, abandoning everything he had built over the ages in pursuit of curiosity alone. Now he felt the strongest urge of his life.

More precisely, a greed that even his lofty intellect could not suppress.

I want him.

No. He had to have him.

A noble soul dwelling in the most corrupted of bodies.

If he could make this strange being, unlike any he had ever seen, completely his own, he felt he might grasp not only its extraordinary nature but also the unknown realm he had longed to reach for thousands of years.

The greatest question—and driving force—that had made Morgoth who he was.

“This won’t do. I can’t hold back.”

The moment Morgoth murmured to himself and rose from his throne—

Flash.

It happened in an instant.

Morgoth vanished without a trace, though he had been dozens of meters[3917] away. The Skeleton King, every nerve on edge, felt a sudden chill rush over him.

Blink!

The thought flashed through his mind, but it was already too late.

His opponent was a Dragon, born with a blessing of mana no other race could approach.

[3917] One meter is about 3.28 ft; several dozen meters is roughly 100 ft or more.

Morgoth cast a wordless spell as naturally as breathing, surpassed the limits of Blink magic, and struck the Skeleton King in the back.

CRRACK!

He couldn't block it or dodge it.

With a dreadful cracking sound, his body flew like a cannonball.

Before the Skeleton King could regain his balance in midair, Morgoth leapt across space again and reached for him.

Fwoosh—slice!

A chillingly low whistle cut through the air by his ear.

At the same time, the Skeleton King put everything he had into widening the distance—and realized his left arm had just been severed from his body.

If he hadn't twisted instinctively at the last moment, he would have lost something other than his arm.

He was aiming for both my legs from the start. He wasn't trying to erase me.

Morgoth's voice followed, confirming his suspicion.

"Stop resisting. You're only wasting time."

It was true. There was nothing to add to it or take away.

The gap between them was dozens of times greater than the distance separating them.

"I've changed my mind. I have to have you."

Morgoth's eyes flickered with greed now, not mere curiosity.

The Skeleton King couldn't fully understand this change in him, but he was certain of one thing.

In the pitch-black darkness where he could see nothing, a faint glimmer of light had finally begun to seep in.

"I understand. I am pretty damn handsome, after all. In fact, it feels unfair to be stuck with a face this ugly."

With a calm retort, the Skeleton King raised the [Hero's Sword] at an angle in his one remaining hand.

One chance.

The only path left to him now. It would surely be the first and last.

Vwooom.

His enormous but murky magical power welled up, wrapping around his body and the silver blade—so utterly at odds with its nature.

Yet even that mighty power, rippling like living mist as it filled the space around them, could not compare to Morgoth's.

"Skeleton King. You awoke in the darkest, coldest grave and took the crown in your hand—the king of the cursed undead."

The Black Dragon Duke Morgoth, once a Dragon Lord who had ruled over three moons and a sun, twelve continents and nine seas, smiled brightly and spread his arms.

His impossibly pure and powerful magical power, worthy of his title as an Archduke of the Demon Realm, pressed down on everything.

“Come to me—to your true master.”

At that very moment—

Fwoooosh!

The space between them disappeared.

No—the Skeleton King saw it twist and vanish at the same time.

But unlike Morgoth, who came hurtling toward him faster than sound with wings of magical power spread wide, the Skeleton King kept both feet planted firmly where he stood.

All he had was the final strike he would make with his one remaining hand.

Shwoosh!

The tip of the sword shot through the air.

Without the slightest tremor.

Boldly, yet calmly.

Carrying a force greater than it had ever borne, it flew in the single direction its wielder intended.

Toward the Skeleton King’s own neck.

“…!”

If a scream could make no sound, would it look like this?

In an instant divided into countless fractions, Morgoth witnessed the unbelievable sight. His eyes flew wide, and he reached out.

And then—

FWOOSH!

A flash deeper and more vast than any darkness erupted, swallowing everything around them.

If someone living in Moscow had survived to see it, they would surely have thought of one word:

Apocalypse.

The world’s death cry.

The end of all living things.

But in that place, already a land of death and little different from part of the Demon Realm, the first to sense danger were not humans.

Thud.

A rumble seemed to rise from deep beneath the earth.

The vast wave stirred something beyond instinct, reaching into the soul. Across the area, countless monsters raised their heads in unison.

Even the large monsters who, seized by a moment's hunger, had been chewing a nearby Orc alive.

Even the Death Knights approaching to punish them, and the Liches raising undead monsters to reinforce their ranks.

Even the dragonkin circling the tall spires and beneath the black clouds.

Every last one of them stopped moving and turned toward the source of the ominous rumble.

The dwelling of the Black Dragon Duke Morgoth, now as good as their new king.

The Dragon Lair.

Whoooosh!

Suddenly, a beam of light shot upward.

No—darkness.

For some reason, it felt not the least bit familiar. It burst from the heart of the lair and rose skyward in a single enormous pillar.

Without end.

Erasing everything in its path.

It split the spires, the dragonkin, and the clouds blocking the light above them, then finally pierced the sky.

And then—

Thud.

The monsters watched the strange sight with vacant stares. At the same moment, they realized how precious the brief time they had just been given was.

Rrrrrumble!

A beam of light poured down through the rift in the torn black clouds, illuminating the earth as it heaved and rolled in waves.

Chapter 1161

A storm.

A storm of power that swept away and destroyed everything in its path—and a colossal explosion born of the collision.

KABOOOOOM!

The world shook beneath a roar that seemed to split the sky. The monsters had been staring blankly at the Dragon Lair, forgetting even the savagery etched into their souls. Now they felt darkness fall over them.

Then came a force they could never have imagined.

—!

Eyes wide. Mouths agape. Legs frozen by primal fear.

The monsters could not even let out a death cry.

No—in their final moments, the pitiful screams they managed were swallowed and erased by the deafening roar.

The impact was so horrific that “unprecedented” hardly did it justice. They were swept away helplessly, crushed into ruin.

RUMBLE, RUMBLE—!

Was this what it would look like if thousands upon thousands of meteors covered the sky?

The colossal castle, shattered into countless fragments by the blast, filled the air as its pieces plunged toward the earth. At the ends of their destructive arcs stood the monsters, frozen like statues.

CRASH! CRASH-CRASH-CRASH!

Destruction and death.

Those two things ruled the area in an instant. Sky and earth shuddered.

Everything mixed together.

Buried. Crumbling.

There was no way to stop it, no time to flee far enough.

Their tough hides and skin—so resilient that ordinary artillery could barely hurt them. Their bones, harder than alloy, and the immense durability those bones gave them.

Even the powerful magical power unique to high-tier monsters, which made all of it possible.

Nothing they possessed could save them from the death bearing down on them.

However brave a fighting dog might be, a tiger would still devour it. Strength yielded to greater strength.

CRUNCH! CRACK!

An ogre with both legs crushed let out a shriek. A Troll, half its body torn away by a fragment that had flashed past in an instant, shuddered and fell.

Even the Wyverns, descendants of Dragons who claimed the open sky as their domain, would never fly again.

Those closest to the explosion's center had either died the moment the shock wave reached them or were now falling helplessly, their proud wings gone.

The explosion of power spread in every direction beyond the vast Dragon Lair. Its unprecedented magical power engulfed the monster army that had been in the area.

Relentlessly. Greedily.

The wave of death seemed as if it would never end. Only after swallowing tens of thousands of monsters did it begin to subside.

And at the center of it all, one being opened his eyes.

Psshh.

Ash slid down his slender frame.

Morgoth rose from the ashes of the Dragon Lair—no, even calling it a ruin would be too generous now—and turned to look around.

The earth had been overturned as if by a massive earthquake. Monster corpses lay piled like mountains. Green blood flowed in rivers, while a single shaft of sunlight peered through a break in the dark clouds at the dreadful scene.

Yet in this moment, not a hint of anger shone in the Black Dragon's obsidian eyes.

"What a sight."

The brief exclamation slipped through his parched lips.

That was all.

Though a moment's carelessness had cost him countless subordinates, Morgoth didn't care in the slightest.

More precisely, he had no reason to care.

He had gained a treasure far more precious and fascinating than those trifling losses.

"To obtain something, one must pay a fitting price. Don't you agree?"

It sounded like a question to himself, but an answer came before long.

From right at his feet.

"Shut… up."

At the faint voice, as hazy as a broken radio, Morgoth breathed a sigh of relief.

"I'm glad you still have some strength left. I was worried you might be erased."

He wasn't exaggerating.

The shock wave from the collision of two immense, utterly different forces had been truly terrifying.

If Morgoth hadn’t used all his power to protect himself, his entire body might now have been covered not in dust, but in his own blood.

“Still, there was some unintended damage… What can you do? This, too, must be the order of things, determined by someone.”

Morgoth smiled and brushed the dust from his shoulder. Like the dust drifting away in a pale cloud, the deaths of inferior monsters meant nothing to him.

Only one being mattered now: the one before him, his greatest interest and his sole objective.

“Thank you for holding on. You’ve exceeded my expectations in every way.”

In truth, even *exceeded* didn’t begin to cover it.

The blow his opponent had aimed at himself, prepared to be erased, had awakened a sensation Morgoth had forgotten over the ages.

Tap. Drip, drip.

Liquid began to wet the ground at his feet.

Morgoth frowned at his own silver blood, gleaming like molten silver, and at the blade jutting through his palm.

“Yes. So this is pain.”

A sensation he hadn’t felt in a thousand years.

It hurt all the more for that. Stung all the more.

Perhaps the memory of the last time he had felt pain made it worse—the day he had also endured a humiliation greater than the pain itself.

“…Asmodeus.”

Morgoth whispered the name. Then, as if shaking off the memory, he yanked the [Hero’s Sword] free and seized it.

Crash!

The blade split in two, and both pieces plunged deep into the ground, reflecting the image of their owner, now reduced to a head.

“Skeleton King. King of the cursed wraiths.”

Morgoth slowly bent toward the Skeleton King, who glared up at him, and stroked the skull where blue ghostly flames flickered in place of eyes.

“Can you see it? Your true self.”

“I told you… to shut up.”

“Calm your anger. You need only acknowledge and accept where you came from—and whom you should be with.”

His captivating voice rang out like a hypnotic spell.

But the Skeleton King didn’t waver.

Clinging to a thread of consciousness that seemed ready to snap, he squeezed out what little strength remained and spoke.

“You really are different from that guy.”

"That guy?"

"Yeah. An arrogant, downright devious human. But…"

That guy—Jin Taekyung—had once told him:

You're just you.

And—

"He's my friend."

"…!"

"He's the one who pulled me out of that godforsaken darkness. He's the one who showed me a new world I'd never known."

He had seen so much.

He had learned so much.

He had left the Gate, where only darkness and death churned, and spent time with everyone beneath the shining sun.

There had been happy days and sad days, but every moment had been dazzling.

Because he wasn't alone anymore.

Because he was with them.

That was enough.

"So quit wasting your time with that stupid bullshit. You'd better get ready."

The Skeleton King smiled.

Brighter and more radiant than ever.

"My friends will be here soon."

At that moment—

Flick.

Like a lamp going out, the ghostly flames flickering in his empty eye sockets suddenly vanished.

"…Your friends, you say?"

Morgoth turned the Skeleton King's final words over in his mind. The Skeleton King had finally lost his grip on consciousness, leaving Morgoth to ponder them alone.

Friend.

A familiar word, yet strange, as though he were hearing it for the first time.

Though he had once spent many years among humans in another world, he had never been able to understand friendship.

Why did people who shared not a drop of blood care so deeply for one another? Why did they sometimes make the foolish choice to give their lives for each other?

Morgoth knew all too well that they did such things. Why they did so remained a source of fascination and astonishment to him.

First, that the Skeleton King—nothing more than a cursed Undead Monster—could show such humanity.

And second—

Jin Taekyung.

A human who might have changed the Skeleton King into this extraordinary being.

There's more I need to find out.

Of course, Morgoth already knew about Jin Taekyung.

The savior of a new age. The center of this world, a young hero who stood at the head of them all.

After Cheon Taemin, Jin Taekyung was among those Morgoth had to watch most carefully. That hadn't changed.

Now, though, Morgoth was intensely curious about him in a way he hadn't been before.

"Yes. I'll have to get ready, as you advised."

Morgoth murmured to the silent skull, then looked out over the earth. The rumbling had finally stopped.

Perhaps it was the shaft of sunlight peeking through the split dark clouds, but the overturned, fractured land had lost much of the pitch-black color that had made it resemble the Demon Realm—and much of the dense magical power that had permeated it.

Morgoth didn't care.

He began to rouse the endless power within his heart: magical power, nearly infinite and utterly pure, born of corruption.

Or rather, he was about to.

Then he sensed someone he hadn't expected.

Vwoom.

The magical power that had seemed ready to erupt like a volcano sank back down. So did the Black Dragon's gaze.

The air trembled uneasily. The wind fell still. Morgoth's tightly closed lips parted.

"My apologies. I didn't realize a guest had arrived."

Dark mist drifted away as he spoke in a low voice.

Beyond it, someone answered.

"I'm asking because I'm curious."

The voice was calm, yet seething like lava.

"What's that in your hand?"

Chapter 1162

For an instant, it was as if the world had stopped.

The faint haze of magical power around me, the mountains of monster corpses, the roars of the monsters that had survived—all of it vanished.

I could no longer feel or see any of it.

Only one sight remained: far away, a man with pitch-black hair hanging down like a cloak held a pure-white skeleton in his hand. The two of them were burned into my retinas as though they were the only things left in the world.

Pain clenched my heart.

“What are you holding?”

My restrained voice crossed the hundred or so meters[3918] between us. At the other end stood a man gazing silently at me.

No—a wicked Black Dragon wearing human skin.

“Ah. This?”

His voice was beautiful enough to seem otherworldly, and carried an evil so pure it was all the more horrifying.

“A clue to satisfying a desire I’ve held for a very long time. And a valuable trophy.”

One corner of Morgoth’s mouth curled upward.

“Perhaps someone’s friend, too.”

“…!”

“A friendship between a human and a monster. A moving story. Judging by the fact that you’ve come here alone, it seems it was all true.”

I didn’t know exactly what had happened here, or what had been said.

But I was certain of one thing.

The Skeleton King had done everything he could, and he’d done it for me—for all of us.

That was why I couldn’t ask the most important question. His obsidian eyes watched me closely, taking in every part of me.

“Are you afraid?”

As if he’d read my mind. I answered briefly.

“Yeah.”

“Of what?”

“There’s a crazy Dragon standing in front of me, and he’s holding someone I know very well. I want him to still be alive.”

Maybe it was how readily I’d answered. After a brief silence, Morgoth gave a quiet laugh.

[3918] About 100 meters is about 330 ft.

"You're honest. Almost disconcertingly so."

"So? Your answer?"

"Didn't I already tell you? A valuable trophy. He was so violent in his rampage that he's a little damaged, but I have no desire to see him shattered to pieces."

The meaning was clear.

He was still alive.

The Skeleton King.

It was the answer I'd been desperately waiting for since the moment I set foot in this godforsaken ruin. Only then did I let out the breath I'd been holding.

"Thanks, you son of a bitch."

"Don't mention it. I couldn't pass up such a precious opportunity after all this time."

"You don't make a habit of taking hostages, do you?"

"Hostage-taking? My intellect and stature are far too great for such cheap amusement."

"That's good to hear."

"Perhaps. Or perhaps it's the worst news you could have heard. I draw a clear distinction between trophies and everything else."

"A distinction?"

"If something is too dangerous to possess, it must be destroyed. That way, there's no trouble later."

Morgoth's smile deepened.

"Just like you."

At that moment—

Vwoom.

Magical power churned around us. A wave of power, unbelievably pure and vast.

And murderous intent so vivid I could almost touch it.

"Was this your plan from the start?"

"No. But the moment we first met, I realized I might make the same mistake Asmodeus once did. And, more than anything…"

His gaze swept over me, unpleasant in its mixture of interest and regret, as though it could see through my entire body.

"Prey."

His hair, long enough to reach the ground, rose into the air like the wings of a being from myth.

Not an angel's wings. A demon's.

"You already see me as prey, don't you, Jin Taekyung? Young, strong human hero."

For an instant, silence hung between us. Then I spoke.

"Yeah. I do."

A Hunter. A sword and shield for humanity, and a hunter.

But that wasn't the only reason I'd come to face him head-on.

If Morgoth had truly been someone I could trust, I would have gladly done whatever he wanted. I would have bowed at his feet. If he'd told me to cut off my own arms and legs, I would have done it.

My life?

If the deaths of Cheon Taemin and me could bring peace to billions of people, I would have given up my life without a second thought.

That was my duty.

But just as Morgoth had understood something when he first saw me, I'd understood something about him.

His eyes.

They were so clear they seemed pure—and no different from a child's eyes as he watched an ant crawl across the asphalt on a midsummer afternoon.

That was why tens of millions of lives had been ground to dust.

Right here, in the very place where I stood.

And there was one more thing.

"He's not a trophy."

"What?"

"He's not some trophy. That guy."

My voice boiled over, so strange it sounded like someone else's. I took a step.

Slowly. Heavily.

As I put my foot down harder than ever before, memories as vivid as yesterday sank in deeper than the footprint it left.

Thud.

"Human, why don't you make a deal with me instead?"

"A deal?"

Yeah. It was there.

An A-rank Gate. Black Wizard's Black Forest.

We'd first met in that dark, damp forest thick with dead trees. And then we'd stayed together.

For far longer than I'd expected.

Thud.

"Hey, Warlord Mon."

"Do not call me by such a name. I am the master of the Black Forest and commander of the mighty undead legion."

"Hmm. All right."

“At last, you understand.”

“So, Golgoli.”

“…Damn it.”

I couldn’t say exactly when it had happened—when I’d begun to see him as more than just a monster.

“Something wrong? Why’ve you been so down all day?”

“I was just thinking about something.”

“What?”

“What kind of being was I, in the past?”

That day, I’d told him as he brooded that I didn’t really know, but he’d probably been a pretty decent guy.

I’d let the words slip as though I were talking to myself, embarrassed for no good reason. He hadn’t forgotten them.

“Human, I have a question.”

Even now, I could see it all clearly.

The spearhead of White Flame, which the Arch Lich had sent flying at me when I was too exhausted and injured to move.

The Skeleton King forcing his way out of my Inventory by his own power and shielding me with his entire body.

“Why…?”

“Human. I have a question.”

That voice I’d thought I would never hear again.

“What you said to me before—did you mean it?”

“Of course I did.”

Only after hearing my answer did the dim lights in his eyes curve like a crescent moon.

“I see.”

The Skeleton Warlord I’d first met in the Black Forest fell.

“You asked me why.”

Then, on human land, a new being who’d sacrificed himself to protect humans rose once more with a shining crown.

He gave back the words I’d once said to him—words he would never forget.

“You’re cunning, but you’re a pretty decent human. That’s all.”

The Skeleton King.

King and master of the dead who wander the Nine Springs.

And…

My friend.

Hot.

My eyes, fixed solely on Morgoth. My two dantians, pouring out Scorching Yang Qi without pause like a volcano erupting after a long wait.

And the step I took, carrying every memory that had just passed through me.

Crack.

A deep rumble spread. The devastated ground crumbled again.

Hairline fractures spread in every direction like a spiderweb, then erupted.

Fwoosh—KABOOM!

Flamefire Path.

I shot forward as a single, blazing streak of fire.

It happened in an instant.

BOOM!

With a sudden flare of blue-black flames, the hundred or so meters[3919] between the two of them disappeared at once.

No—*vaporized* might have been more accurate.

The heat Morgoth felt was that horrifyingly intense, and the speed surpassed even sound.

But—

I can see it.

The Black Dragon's obsidian eyes flashed as he read it all: the streak of fire rushing up to his face, and something suddenly emerging from its immense heat.

Whoosh!

"…!"

Morgoth's eyes flew wide. A silver spearhead slashed down at an angle, reflected in them.

Where had it come from? How?

He hadn't sensed the power of any magic.

Before he could find an answer, the flames carried on the spearhead drove into his chest.

Or so it seemed.

For the briefest moment.

Flash—slice!

In a moment split into smaller moments, Morgoth crossed the distance in an instant. He silently raised a hand to touch the area around his chest.

More precisely, to the patch of skin that had been scorched black by the slightest graze.

[3919] About 100 meters is about 330 ft.

"…Hot."

It was only the third time in thousands of years that he'd felt pain.

But unlike the undead monster who'd caused him pain the second time, the human approaching from afar with his spear lowered still held immense power.

Enough to make Morgoth ask with genuine curiosity, "Are you, by any chance, one of my kind?"

Slowly but carefully closing the distance, Jin Taekyung answered calmly.

"Yeah. Long time no see, son."

"Your vulgar speech makes it clear you're not one of my kind…but how can a human grow so strong so quickly?"

Morgoth already knew about Jin Taekyung. He knew a great deal.

And until Morgoth had been summoned to this world, Jin Taekyung's power had been nothing like this.

"A lot's happened. Things even you couldn't possibly imagine."

"Things even I couldn't imagine…"

How could that not fascinate him?

But Morgoth forced down the curiosity rising from deep within him. The human before him was too dangerous to let a moment's curiosity distract him.

"A pity. I'll never get to hear that interesting story of yours."

Muttering under his breath, Morgoth curled both hands like claws and seized the empty air.

No—he tore it.

Grrrrrrk.

Warped space opened its jaws. Beyond the gap, where only darkness rippled, beings that had remained hidden until now emerged.

Clank, clank.

Sharp spears and blades. Armor covering every inch of their bodies.

There were hundreds of them—thousands—and they resembled one another like twins born of the same womb. Jin Taekyung recalled the first day he'd returned to this world.

"Those are…"

"My most loyal guardians."

Dragon-tooth soldiers.

Guardians born of Dragons and existing only to serve Dragons.

But they weren't the only thing that made Jin Taekyung freeze.

"…Faye Chen?"

A familiar face appeared among the Dragon-tooth soldiers, and a low groan escaped his lips.

Chapter 1163

Partings always brought sadness and regret.

All the more so when death made the parting with someone close permanent.

But this was never the kind of reunion he wanted.

"…Faye Chen?"

The name came out like a groan.

Even from a distance, the face was instantly recognizable. And yet it had never looked so unfamiliar.

No.

The faces.

"Long ago, in the world where I lived, there were some exceptionally gifted beings. They were called warriors or heroes."

The wicked Dragon's voice, steeped in old memories, reached Jin Taekyung as he stood frozen like a statue.

"At first, they were a nuisance. I didn't much care for them coming all the way to my lair and behaving rudely over some trivial matter."

Morgoth had never quite understood them.

All he'd done was burn a few cities and wipe out a kingdom. Why come all the way to his lair to make a scene?

"At least, that was how I felt until I met one human."

He had stood out even among the hundreds of heroes who had come before him.

He was strong, resilient, and fought more desperately than anyone.

Perhaps that was why, when the man died without leaving so much as a proper corpse—reduced to a little pool of blood like all the other intruders—Morgoth felt regret for the first time.

Along with it came a powerful desire to possess him, rising from deep within.

"That was when I began collecting 'trophies' in earnest."

Not mere cold, hard gold and jewels, but special trophies, each retaining its own memories and light.

Humans, elves, dwarves. Sometimes monsters.

Those he could force to submit, he did. Those who refused every offer, he killed so he could keep them by his side anyway.

His most precious trophies, given the name Guardians.

And he had continued this fascinating collection in the unfamiliar world called Earth.

"They're still unfinished, but the material is good. The results are excellent."

"…!"

“What do you think of my new Guardians?”

Jin Taekyung didn’t answer the question, which was brimming with satisfaction.

He couldn’t. All he could do was look at the bloodless faces now standing at the head of the Dragon-tooth soldiers and recite their names to himself.

Faye Chen, Joel Schumacher, Pablo Albatroses…

Seven names.

Seven S-rank Hunters.

Heroes who had represented their countries. Comrades who had trusted one another to watch their backs.

Over the past several days of the Black Dragon’s great invasion, they had been reported killed in battle, their bodies never found.

Now they stood here.

Denied rest even in death.

Puppets robbed of their very souls.

Shing.

They raised sharp swords, maces, halberds, and shields. They drew their bows.

At Jin Taekyung, of all people.

At the one light that had shown them the way when they could see nothing in the darkness. Their hope.

Fwoooosh.

A cold wind swept across the devastated land.

The monsters had surrounded him on every side. Their murderous intent whipped around him like blades. Beyond the thousand Dragon-tooth soldiers forming an immense wall before their master, the wicked Dragon smiled, his teeth gleaming white.

“Now, shall we begin?”

Those words were the signal.

Rumble-rumble-rumble!

A wave of monsters poured in without end, shaking heaven and earth.

At the same time, Jin Taekyung’s frozen expression shifted. His eyes narrowed to half-lidded slits.

Whoosh—KABOOM!

Blue-black flames burst forth, coiling around his spearhead and flooding the whole area with blinding light.

Slice!

He slashed.

Thwack! Thud-thud-thud!

He stabbed.

Crunch!

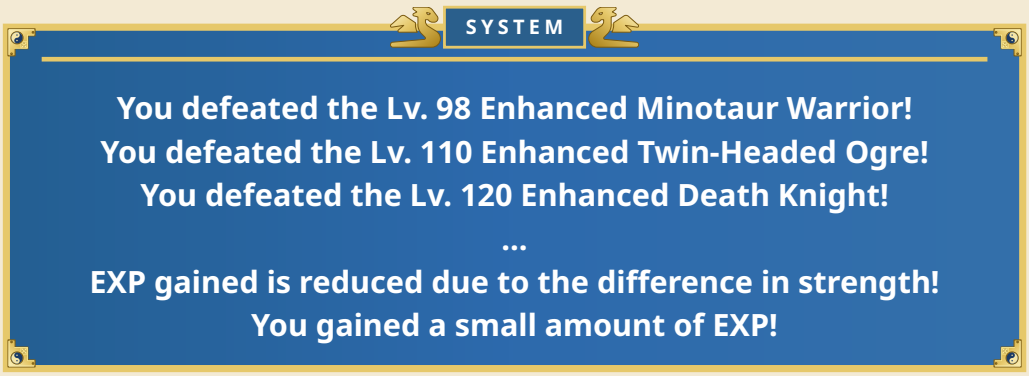
He smashed and crushed.

And then—

Rumble!

He pushed forward.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



Jin Taekyung let out the breath he'd been holding.

The chimes ringing incessantly in his ears seemed to grow more distant. The monsters' stench and roars had never felt closer or clearer.

"Gwoooar!"

Suddenly, a shadow fell across hundreds of heads.

A Cyclops—a one-eyed giant as tall as a walking skyscraper—slammed both fists down with a roar that shook heaven and earth.

BOOM!

Compressed air exploded. The mountain of force behind its fists crushed and burst everything they touched.

Everything except the one person it had to bring down.

...!

By the time the giant spotted the human, smaller than its palm, a spearhead wreathed in blue-black flames was already driving into its single eye.

Thud!

The spear pierced the eye as easily as a knife through tofu. The terrible heat carried through its tip melted the giant's brain, and its massive body toppled.

Whoooosh—BOOM!

A thick cloud of dust billowed upward.

Monsters caught beneath the dead giant screamed. Others lost sight of their target in the dust and hesitated.

They had no idea it was the last mistake they would ever make.

Fwoosh!

The cloud of dust split in two.

No—it evaporated.

A spear shot through the air like a ray of light, sweeping through the Liches commanding the monster army that had survived the enormous explosion.

Rumble!

Dozens of layered defensive spells were useless. So were Blink spells cast in the blink of an eye.

The unprecedented force behind the spearhead rendered them all meaningless.

Its power and speed were so astonishing that even *overwhelming* fell short.

“What an interesting world. Truly.”

Morgoth was genuinely impressed as he watched Jin Taekyung dominate the battlefield like the hero of an ancient myth.

He had seen and fought countless powerful beings over the past several thousand years.

Yet neither an elven Elder who had lived nearly a thousand years, nor a dwarf king blessed by the rocky mountains, nor the human knight called the greatest on the continent had displayed martial prowess like this.

No. None of them had come close.

“Asmodeus, I think I’m beginning to understand why you failed.”

The humans of this unfamiliar world were strong.

They grew stronger through a mysterious power even Morgoth couldn’t fathom. And a tiny chosen few surpassed their given limits by so much that they became superhumans.

Like Cheon Taemin, who was as good as dead now.

Or that recklessly brave young human hero.

And so—

Vwoom.

He had to crush them.

Even if it meant setting aside his pride.

“Ice Wall.”

A short Spell, yet one imbued with powerful Magic no other race could match, rang across the battlefield.

Fwoooosh.

Cold fierce enough to freeze everything swept across hundreds of meters.[3920]

At its far end stood the human who had reduced the endless flood of high-level monsters to a mere flock of sheep.

[3920] One meter is about 3.28 ft; hundreds of meters are roughly hundreds of yards.

Rumble!

Suddenly, an enormous shadow fell across the ground.

Ice walls several meters[3921] thick and ten times as tall erupted around Jin Taekyung, enclosing him on every side. They were less a barrier than a prison.

A prison built solely to hold Jin Taekyung—and a coffin prepared for his death.

“Hell Fire.”

Fwoooosh.

The sky turned red.

A sphere of flame emerged from between the dark clouds, enormous beyond anything a Grand Mage of any world could have imagined. Its terrible heat crashed down upon the ice walls.

KABOOM!

The flash was fierce enough to blind anyone who faced it.

The flames, worthy of being called the fires of Hell itself, melted the ice wall and burned everything trapped inside.

The thousand monsters thrown away as bait—and one human who hadn’t managed to escape the spell’s range in time.

That was what should have happened.

Tap. Tap-tap.

A tiny tremor began among the monsters’ corpses, now reduced to piles of charcoal.

A familiar face emerged from between them. Morgoth licked his lips.

He endured it? That spell just now?

It hadn’t been ordinary Hell Fire.

He had used his own knowledge to push its power and limits to the utmost, then put his full strength behind it.

A direct hit would have left even another Dragon with a potentially fatal wound.

Yet Jin Taekyung had endured all that heat with no way to dodge.

Morgoth muttered, his voice low.

“This is… a little troublesome.”

No, perhaps more than that.

Whenever events exceeded his expectations, some unknown danger lurked behind them.

And this danger was bigger and faster than Morgoth had thought.

Crack—BOOM!

An explosion burst from Jin Taekyung’s toes with a thunderous roar.

[3921] One meter is about 3.28 ft, so several meters are roughly several times that distance in feet.

True to the meaning of Flamefire Path's name, he surged forward, carving a path of blue-black flames.

Slice, rumble!

Everything in his way split and shattered.

If the monster army flooding in from every direction was a wave, he was a spearhead piercing through it.

One strike.

Then another.

An ogre's head burst beneath his fist. A Death Knight struck by his whip-like kick never rose again.

And then, in the eyes of the monsters falling and spraying green blood, Jin Taekyung saw something familiar.

Fear.

It was fear.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

You have met the activation requirements for One Against a Thousand!
The effect of the Title One Against a Thousand has greatly intimidated your enemies!
The effect of the Title One Against a Thousand has greatly increased your Intimidation!
Enemies frightened by your Intimidation are beginning to retreat!

A sturdy dam crumbled.

The instinct that had craved nothing but slaughter faded, and a strange emotion called fear filled the space it left behind.

"Gwoooar!"

The monsters turned and fled, their roars stripped of their former ferocity. Jin Taekyung didn't bother chasing them.

He still had enemies left.

And the battle about to begin would decide not only the outcome here today, but everything that came after.

Squish. Squish.

His weary steps carried him through pools of blood.

Beyond the thousand Dragon-tooth soldiers still standing like iron towers, Morgoth watched him for a moment, then spoke.

“You’re tired.”

Jin Taekyung answered in a weary voice.

“Thanks to you.”

“Do you think you can defeat me in that state?”

“Who knows? Maybe, if you clear away the guys in front of you.”

“Perhaps. If I were a little more foolish, I might have.”

Morgoth fixed his gaze on Jin Taekyung, his eyes sunk deep, and continued.

“But I’m afraid I’ve already made up my mind. Today, just this once, I’ll set aside my pride.”

Clank.

At Morgoth’s gesture, the Dragon-tooth soldiers stepped forward.

Fwoooosh!

Far away, beyond the horizon where the monster army had vanished, a flash of light flared.

Chapter 1164

It was a pillar of light, vast and dazzling.

Flash!

A brilliance that seized everyone's attention in an instant.

Morgoth knew better than anyone what had descended from the distant sky. He simply couldn't understand how it had become reality.

"How?"

Someone answered the question that slipped from his lips.

"Why are you so surprised?"

Jin Taekyung.

It was him.

Despite the exhaustion in his voice, a faint smile—one that hadn't been there before—rested on his lips.

"Just accept it. The weather's nice. Don't overthink it."

"…What?"

Morgoth instinctively looked up, following Jin Taekyung's pointing finger. Only then did he realize what he'd overlooked.

It had split apart.

The dark clouds had blocked every trace of clear sky and bright sunlight. His magical power had cut everything off from the world as it was. But the Black Dragon's vast territory, once almost another Demon Realm, had begun to lose its hold.

The rift had opened because of Morgoth's own greed—and the sacrifice of someone willing to face even Erasure.

"I told you. He wasn't some trophy."

At Jin Taekyung's low voice, Morgoth thought of the precious trophy he had just moved to his subspace.

No. The Skeleton King.

"Yes. Perhaps he wasn't."

Resolve had led to sacrifice, and sacrifice had brought about this upheaval. The tremendous explosion of power the Skeleton King had unleashed by throwing away his life had made all this possible.

That was the chief reason the Magic of an utterly insignificant human had dared encroach on the great Black Dragon's domain.

But…

"What can a force that small possibly change?"

His voice steady, Morgoth looked toward the distant horizon. More precisely, toward the group coming into view beyond the fading flash.

BOOM!

Before the light had vanished, a thunderous boom shook heaven and earth.

The monster army charged at the humans who had suddenly appeared to block its retreat. Over the monsters' heads poured an endless rain of fire, unleashed by humanity's strongest War Mage.

"A Warp on this scale, and wide-area Magic. Quite impressive. A step above the human mage from a few days ago."

Quite impressive.

That was all Morgoth had to say about Magic Johnson, but there wasn't a trace of arrogance in his appraisal.

Dragons were mysterious creatures born for Magic—Magic itself, one might say—and Morgoth stood at the pinnacle of their kind. Before he had even reached adulthood, he had touched the limits of Magic. To him, the Magic of other races was little more than child's play. That remained true even in this unfamiliar world called Earth.

Otherwise, Merlin—the Grand Mage who, after Siegfried Bassmann's death, had been one of only two left alongside Magic Johnson—wouldn't have chosen to blow himself up in the battle a few days ago.

"He caught on quickly. He saw me collecting his comrades' bodies and chose death without hesitation."

Morgoth had felt a little regret at losing such a rare trophy as a Grand Mage. Not anymore.

"I suppose I should thank you. I never expected you to give me such fine trophies."

Greed he had held in check until now glinted in his obsidian eyes.

Of the thousands of humans closing in as they crushed the monster army, only two posed even the slightest threat to him.

But even Magic Johnson and Chuck Hagel were no more than trophies in Morgoth's eyes. Jin Taekyung, already worn down by considerable fatigue, faced a wall of a thousand Dragon-tooth soldiers—each one practically a Named Monster in its own right.

The seven Guardians stood with them, reborn far more powerful than before.

"Nothing has changed. This battle is over."

He was right.

Anyone would have thought so. The odds were overwhelmingly in Morgoth's favor.

And yet…

If that was true, why was Jin Taekyung still smiling?

In Jin's heat-shimmering eyes, Morgoth saw someone he barely recognized: himself, his face rigid despite the words he'd just spoken.

"What's so funny?"

Unable to hold back, Morgoth demanded an answer. Jin Taekyung raised the spear he'd been leaning on like a staff.

"I just feel a little better."

"…You feel better?"

"Yeah. I've been in situations like this plenty of times. Heard what you just said plenty of times, too."

Jin Taekyung spat out the phlegm that had gathered in his mouth.

"You know, the usual crap. 'I'm different from everyone else.' 'I never let my guard down.' 'I'll kill you for sure.' 'It's all over.' And so on."

All those times he'd hovered between life and death.

They were memories so awful Jin Taekyung never wanted to revisit them. But right now, remembering them felt different.

Why?

Simple.

"The weird thing is, not one of those bastards ever followed through on what they said."

It was true. He'd fought every one of them, and he'd beaten every one of them.

Even with his arms and legs crushed, his insides churned to mush, and death at his heels, he had survived.

But perhaps the deepest reason he'd won so many hopeless battles wasn't just his strange power, the System.

"Why was that? Some of them really could've killed me. So why did they waste time talking and doing pointless things? Why leave themselves open?"

He was afraid.

Always. At every moment.

In battle, and even in the quiet moments of everyday life.

He feared that someday a powerful enemy would kill him. It tormented him that he might have to get back on his feet at the cost of someone else's life.

So whenever he faced an enemy, he hurled insults. He piled on every kind of abuse, then dragged up even the smallest scraps of anger and grief buried deep inside him to smother his fear.

He had to make himself stronger somehow.

People called him a hero, but he knew he was far too weak to carry that burden.

Looking back, though, he hadn't been the only one afraid of the person across from him.

"Then, all of a sudden, I started feeling better."

Jin Taekyung had finally realized something.

"The guys I beat were afraid of me, too."

"…!"

"All that crap they said came from fear. Just like yours does now."

Jin Taekyung smiled faintly at Morgoth's suddenly frozen face.

"What, did I hit a nerve?"

Morgoth didn't answer.

No—he couldn't. Everything Jin Taekyung had said was true. His pride and insight were too great for him to deny it.

"…Fear."

He'd forgotten it. Or rather, he'd tried to forget the one time he had ever felt that pathetic emotion.

But at last, Morgoth had no choice but to admit that what he felt toward Jin Taekyung was more than caution.

"Yes. I see. I was a little afraid of you, too."

The strength of their fear might differ, but its nature was the same.

Muttering in a low voice, Morgoth looked at the tiny human who had dared to make him feel afraid.

"But I swear one thing to you."

Vwooom.

The wind stopped. The air around them shuddered.

"I will be different from anyone you've ever faced."

At that moment—

Fwoosh!

Darkness erupted around Morgoth, engulfed his body, and swelled. It rose as high as the spire that now lay in ruins and spread as wide as a fortress wall.

Jin Taekyung instinctively understood what the phenomenon before him meant.

Polymorph.

Would the world look like this if the sun vanished without a trace?

The Black Dragon finally shed his human skin. Darkness surrounded him, blackening the sky overhead and the battlefield for hundreds of meters[3922] around him.

As if announcing the end of the world.

But Jin Taekyung's gaze didn't waver. Not even as the darkness, its work done, slowly dissipated and a thousand Dragon-tooth soldiers charged toward him at their master's command.

It's coming. It has to.

[3922] One hundred meters is about 328 ft.

He knew that just as darkness existed wherever there was light, a new light awaited beyond this darkness.

And his faith was rewarded.

Just as Jin Taekyung had once answered the voice of someone crying out for salvation.

Flash!

In an instant, the world lit up.

The horizon, sinking into darkness like an extinguished campfire, and the land, being swallowed by an even deeper gloom, were bathed in light.

Dozens, then hundreds of pillars of it.

The hearts of those who had crossed thousands—tens of thousands—of kilometers,[3923] again and again, to answer the call.

"…What is this?"

Countless Warp Magic Formations set the horizon ablaze. At Morgoth's groan, rumbling like thunder from high in the distant sky, Jin Taekyung spoke.

"I'll swear one thing, too."

His low voice carried on the wind. He stepped forward and leveled his spear at the enemies bearing down on him.

"You'll end up just like them."

Fwoosh—slice!

As fierce flames rose like dawn and lit the battlefield, a mighty roar raced along the horizon and shook the field of battle.

[3923] One thousand kilometers is about 620 mi; ten thousand kilometers is about 6,200 mi.

Chapter 1165

Rrrrrumble!

If light could turn to liquid and overflow, would it look like this?

The ground shook as if an earthquake had struck. Watching waves of aura wash across the horizon and surge toward him, Morgoth knew instinctively:

If he didn't act now, he might never get another chance to unleash everything he had.

"Answer my call."

His low voice reverberated far and deep.

Language had power.

And the ancient Dragon's words, imbued with immense magical power, reached a realm no other race had ever entered.

Craaaack!

The empty air split open.

At the same time, countless eyes gleamed ominously from within the dark rift in space.

"Gwoooar!"

Shadows large and small plummeted to the ground with roars full of killing intent.

With a single Warp spell, Morgoth had gathered his remaining forces from the cities they occupied across the region. He gave the order in a cold voice.

"Kill them all."

That one command was the signal.

Monsters charged at humans, humans charged at monsters, and soon light and darkness blurred together.

Clang-clang-clang!

Thwack! Splatter!

The shriek of steel and the sickening sound of torn flesh swallowed the battle cries. Blood mist hung thick across the battlefield, and the Black Dragon watched it all without a flicker in his eyes.

His shock had lasted only an instant.

Morgoth had already regained his composure. His mind was colder than ever.

Even if his elite monster legion, the force that had guarded his stronghold, had suffered heavy losses, he still had the reinforcements he'd just summoned. That alone was enough.

No—even if every one of those monsters were wiped out, it wouldn't matter.

The fate of the world hung on this battle. Its outcome would be decided not by mere numbers, but by whether one human lived or died.

Jin Taekyung.

There he was.

A blue-black flame slowly cutting through the thousand Dragon-tooth soldiers surrounding him like a dense forest.

At the same time, the short vow that small, insignificant human had spoken earlier echoed in Morgoth's ears—and chilled a corner of his heart.

Me? Morgoth? Becoming just like them?

The Black Dragon bared his gleaming teeth and let out a low growl.

Wrong. He was nothing like anyone else.

With the Demon King Asmodeus gone, Morgoth alone was the true ruler destined to reign over every world—and that was exactly what he would become.

"Fire Lance."

Fwoosh—KABOOM!

A dozen or so spears of flame appeared out of nowhere, about to rain down on Jin Taekyung.

"Ice Blaster!"

A desperate shout rang out from somewhere. A massive spike of ice tore through space and intercepted the flames.

KABOOM!

Space shook.

The deflected flames struck the empty ground. Steam billowed up, thick enough to obscure everything within a hundred-meter radius.[3924]

But the Black Dragon's gleaming eyes saw clearly through it all.

A group of people covered head to toe in blood and dust, their eyes still blazing.

"Clear a…!"

The towering Grand Mage caught his breath, then roared.

"Clear a path!"

Whoosh! Whoooooosh!

With a battle cry that seemed to pierce the sky, the thousands-strong suicide squad—the first to reach this dreadful battlefield—charged toward the Dragon-tooth soldiers.

No.

They charged toward their Alliance Leader, their one and only hope.

It was a battle no one could control.

BOOM!

[3924] A hundred meters is about 330 ft.

Clang! Krrrunch!

Flashes and explosions burst and mingled without pause.

Blood sprayed like fountains. Severed arms and legs rolled limply across the ground.

And through the chaos, a voice I'd been waiting for reached my ears.

"Wind Cutter!"

Magic Johnson. There he was.

At the same time, the blades of wind that rushed in passed close by the two Dragon-tooth soldiers charging at my flank.

Shwaa!

Two heads floated into the air.

If he'd aimed anywhere but their necks, even the Grand Mage's Magic wouldn't have been enough to kill them in one blow. But Magic Johnson had fought them before, in the Middle East. He knew their weakness exactly.

He also knew this wasn't the time for a long, friendly greeting.

"Fuck."

To the man who'd greeted me with a single syllable, I sent a dagger I'd just summoned from my Inventory.

More precisely, I threw it at the Dragon-tooth soldier lunging over his shoulder.

Thwack!

A dagger thrown with all a normal Murim martial artist's strength would rightly be called a hidden weapon. But my Strength had long since surpassed that of most large monsters.

The dagger flashed forward and shattered the helmet made of some unknown metal—and the head beneath it. Drenched in the enemy's brain matter, Magic Johnson muttered another curse.

"This is hell."

"Sorry, but it's too late to go back."

"Everyone here knows that. We knew, and we came anyway."

That was true.

They'd known their lives would be in danger, yet they'd answered my call willingly.

There were only twenty S-rank Hunters left in the entire world—or rather, now only a dozen or so—and they'd chosen only the very best before racing here from all over the globe.

Across continents and oceans.

But the tide of this Great War, with everything humanity had at stake, was still as dark and damp as the clouds overhead.

"Damn it, what the hell? There are this many of those awful things?"

Anyone who'd ever faced a Dragon-tooth soldier would react the same way.

They had more magical power than even the strongest Death Knights, which ranked at the top of A-rank. Their bodies were horribly tough, and they were stubbornly hard to kill.

Calling each one as formidable as a Named Monster would be no exaggeration.

But even Magic Johnson, who knew all this well, didn't know one thing yet.

The Dragon-tooth soldiers weren't the only obstacle we had to overcome to reach Morgoth.

Shiiiiing!

Something shot toward us like a beam of light.

With no time to catch my breath, I angled my spear blade and caught it on the flat.

Clang!

I'd poured plenty of internal energy into the spear, but its shaft still trembled.

Magic Johnson let out a low groan at the familiar face beyond it.

"Faye Chen?"

His mouth fell open. His eyes wavered.

He'd known that old comrade for decades, since the beginning of the Great Cataclysm. Seeing her shook Magic Johnson more than anything had yet. And when the number of familiar faces reached seven, his whole body trembled.

"What is this?"

"Guardians."

"What?"

"That's what Morgoth calls them. His Guardians. They protect him."

"…!"

Magic Johnson clenched his teeth as he understood what I meant.

Even I, who knew nothing about Magic, could clearly sense the magical power controlling them. The Grand Mage would have felt it all the more.

"…Guardians."

Bitterness, anger, grief.

His voice carried them all. Then it gradually quieted, leaving only one.

Anger.

And Magic Johnson wasn't the only one feeling it.

"Near the end of the Great Cataclysm, we talked about it when we were all together."

Boom!

A fist shot forward like a cannonball, followed by a roar.

Chuck Hagel crushed the Dragon-tooth soldiers blocking his path one by one as he went on.

“If we survived this goddamn war, we’d live happier than anyone else in the world until the day we died.”

The fists he kept throwing carried more than the mysterious power called aura.

They carried memories.

The memories of those days, so painful they could have killed him, yet filled with hope that things would soon get better, poured forth with his aura.

“Then why?!”

Krrrunch!

Shattered weapons flew in every direction, along with pieces of the Dragon-tooth soldiers’ armor and bodies.

And the tears of an old soldier who had lost his longtime friends.

“Why are they like this now?!”

His roar held all his grief and anger.

Why had it come to this?

Why couldn’t they keep even that simple promise to live happily for a long time? Why did they have to suffer this humiliation even after death?

But no voice answered his questions.

The only answer was the Black Dragon’s Magic once again filling the sky, and the footsteps of his old comrades as they advanced.

Fwoosh, crackle!

Shiiiiing!

Giga Lightning.

Dozens of bolts plunged down like divine punishment. The seven Guardians and countless Dragon-tooth soldiers charged forward, pitch-black magical power streaming behind them like cloaks.

They came with a force that seemed impossible to stop.

But they didn’t break through.

Because I wasn’t alone anymore.

“Stone Wall!”

A single spell rang through the roar of battle.

Dozens of voices joined in it.

Magic Johnson stood at their head. Behind him were the world’s greatest mages, following humanity’s only Grand Mage.

KABOOM!

The sky darkened, then flashed.

A ceiling of rock suddenly appeared over our allies’ heads. When it met the lightning, a tremendous explosion shook the battlefield.

No—the two spells canceled each other out.

Several mages, unable to withstand the backlash, coughed up blood and fell to their knees. The enraged Black Dragon's roar thundered across the battlefield.

"How dare you!"

Rrrrrumble!

As immense magical power began shaking space again, I shot straight forward, leaving the falling rocks behind me.

Just as I always had.

But one thing was different.

This time, people were following me.

Whooooooosh!

Another group of familiar faces finally broke through the chaotic battlefield.

The brown-haired foreigner at the front tipped his head toward me.

"Too late?"

"Not at all."

"Good. Though I wouldn't have apologized if I were."

That irritating way of speaking was exactly as I remembered it.

Prince Felix had joined us with four S-rank Hunters. He added, "Go. Now. We'll handle things here."

I didn't answer.

I held back the heat rising deep in my chest and pushed forward with all my might.

Behind me, seven S-rank Hunters clashed with their old comrades.

Slice!

I cut one down, then another.

Krrrunch!

Kept going. Didn't stop.

And then—

Crack!

Toward the monster who was the beginning and end of it all.

BOOM!

I shot forward like a streak of flame.

"Morgoth!"

In the Black Dragon's vast, gleaming eyes, a human leaping upward, stomping on thin air, was reflected.

Chapter 1166

Fwoooosh.

For an instant, time slowed.

The sounds around him faded into the distance, and his heartbeat thundered in his ears.

At the same time, instinct and reason whispered in unison.

Now.

His senses sharpened until every hair on his body stood on end. Jin Taekyung shot upward on the explosive force of Flamefire Path and brought his spear down with all his strength.

Toward the Black Dragon's eye—larger than Jin's entire body, and blacker than anything else.

Fwoosh—KABOOM!

A line of fire split the air.

No—the countless seams hidden within it.

Shhhhk.

A chillingly low, faint whistle.

That was all.

Nothing else could be seen or heard.

Even if someone else had been standing right there, watching it all unfold, they would never have understood what had happened.

But the two beings who had finally come face-to-face knew.

That single strike had cut through dozens of layers of the highest-grade defensive magic at once.

I cut it.

A shiver ran up Jin Taekyung's spine.

It worked.

As his insight deepened and his martial prowess grew, he had begun to sense the flow of qi more and more clearly. Now he could sense it in the monster before him, too.

But the spearhead that had torn through the defensive magic never reached its target.

Rrrumble—!

An immense force suddenly fell on him from above.

And the force humanity called gravity was faster and heavier than Jin Taekyung had expected.

Whoooosh—BAM!

A cloud of dust rose in the wake of his body as it slammed down at tremendous speed.

Just as Jin Taekyung had cut through the defensive magic with a single attack, Morgoth had sent him crashing to the ground with overwhelming gravity. The Black Dragon muttered in a low voice.

“Did you think I wouldn’t anticipate even this?”

The words slipping between the Black Dragon’s teeth were more than mere sound.

“Wind Cutter.”

The magic within the Dragon’s words stirred. Countless blades of wind formed, then tore through the cloud of dust.

BOOM!

The thick dust cloud burst apart. Jin Taekyung raced over ground sliced through like tofu, dodging as Morgoth unleashed one spell after another.

Morgoth’s voice continued, almost as if he were talking to himself.

“Thank you. Thanks to you, I’ve finally realized something important.”

Until now, fear had seemed to a great being like Morgoth nothing more than a weak emotion.

So he had tried to forget it.

He simply hadn’t been able to.

But today, watching one human, he had glimpsed a great truth he had been refusing to face.

“If you fully acknowledge and accept the fear lurking in your heart, you can no longer call it fear.”

Yes.

Morgoth believed that was why Jin Taekyung—and humans—could be strong.

Their lives were absurdly short, their bodies fragile.

Humans were undeniably weak. They had neither the long lives of elves, nor the dwarves’ strength, nor monsters’ ability to reproduce quickly.

But because they knew their own weakness and fear, they spent their lives struggling to grow stronger, each in their own way.

Like the person fighting his way through a curtain of magic that now surrounded him on all sides, closing in without a gap, relying on nothing but a single spear.

“And so, I too will grow stronger.”

Morgoth dropped the barest courtesy he had maintained for the sake of his own dignity, not his opponent’s. He let go of the last sliver of arrogance that remained. Then he added quietly:

“Because I’m… afraid of you, you bastard.”

At that moment—

CRACK—KABOOM!

The ground caved in within a radius of a hundred meters[3925] around Jin Taekyung. Countless thorny vines burst through the cracks and surged toward him.

Shwaaa!

A sharp whistle rang out from every direction.

This was no ordinary binding spell, nor were these common thorny vines.

Their stems were as thick as the trunks of mature trees, covered from end to end in enormous thorns.

They had drunk their fill of the Black Dragon's magical power instead of sunlight. Each one was strong enough to crush a human body in an instant, and Jin Taekyung could feel the power within them.

He also knew there was only one way to escape this tenacious magical prison closing in from every direction.

Grit.

He steadied his breathing. Clenched his teeth.

He planted a step with the weight of a thousand geun[3926] and used that foot as his pivot, gathering the internal energy he had left—not even half of what he'd started with—and pouring it into the tip of White Flame.

Then—

He swung.

A storm that swept everything away, and hellfire capable of burning anything.

Whooooooosh!

Fire Dragon's Single Tail.

In the midst of a life-or-death struggle, the first form of the Blazing Flame Divine Spear, at last reaching the edge of its realm, flowed along the spearhead.

The fiery storm spread beyond a single line into a vast circle, hungrily devouring everything in its path.

The ice and lightning that had ceaselessly blanketed the sky and rained down.

The thorny vines that surged from every direction, seeming to swim through the ground.

KABOOOOOM!

White ash and embers that had not yet gone out drifted like snowflakes, brushing past Jin Taekyung as he stood alone and upright in the heat haze rising from the ground.

At the same time, Morgoth instinctively knew.

Now that Jin Taekyung had poured out all the strength he had left at once, this was the moment he had been waiting for.

[3925] A hundred meters is about 328 ft.

[3926] A thousand Korean geun is 600 kg, or about 1,320 lb.

It was why he had waged a relentless war of attrition, using tens of thousands of monsters—and even the thousand Dragon-tooth soldiers he had spent so long creating—as bait.

"Dark Vine."

CRRACK!

Black thorny vines erupted again and surged toward Jin Taekyung.

And that wasn't all.

Rrrrumble!

"Gravity."

A force far beyond the bounds of ordinary gravity magic shook the sky. Magic spells of devastating power filled the gaps, each one as powerful as the dazzling flashes they produced.

All in one direction, for one purpose.

And this time, nothing unexpected happened.

BOOM! Shrrrk!

His knees buckled first under a weight of dozens of metric tons.[3927] Thick thorny vines slithered over him like living snakes and bound his whole body.

At the same time, dozens of spells converged in the air, shining down on one human like a small sun.

Jin Taekyung.

As Morgoth watched him, bound like a criminal and waiting for death to come, a thought suddenly crossed his mind.

If he hadn't been a Dragon.

Or if Jin Taekyung had possessed a Dragon Heart, brimming with power almost without limit like his own, perhaps Jin Taekyung would be the one standing there now instead of him.

But…

At least today, I was stronger.

It was the difference in what they had been born with.

The size of the vessel that could contain their power, the total amount of strength they possessed—those were different.

Morgoth and Jin Taekyung.

Jin Taekyung and Morgoth.

The two beings were different in every way, and each had fought the other with everything they had. But Morgoth's vessel of power was deeper and larger than Jin Taekyung's.

That was all.

[3927] A metric ton is 1,000 kg, or about 2,205 lb.

That was the sole reason this battle—and, beyond it, the fate of the world—had been decided.

Meeting you was the greatest amusement I have ever experienced.

With the highest praise he could offer, the Black Dragon opened his enormous jaws.

Vwooom.

The Dragon's heart, deep within his body, shuddered.

No matter how much he emptied and poured out, pure magical power continued to fill him without end. Its chillingly low rumble swirled between the Dragon's teeth, dark as a cave.

Dragon Breath.

A supreme power granted only to dragonkin.

Because he feared harming the Dragon-tooth soldiers, and because he had so little time to release it, its range and destructive power fell far short of their usual level.

But it was more than enough.

His only purpose was to erase a single human from this world without leaving a trace.

Jin Taekyung. The weakest of humans, and yet a hero more resilient than anyone.

Gooooong.

His chest suddenly swelled.

At the same time, the immense magical power flowing from the Dragon Heart—the purest, deepest darkness—finally became a single flash and shot forward.

Carrying heartfelt respect, and a murderous intent heavier still.

This is the end.

At that moment—

KABOOOOOM!

A beam of darkness, black enough to swallow the sun, tore through space like a bolt of lightning.

The world stopped.

Or at least, that was how it seemed to Jin Taekyung.

But his eyes, dimmer than usual, weren't fixed on the countless spells coloring the air, or the Dragon's breath, which held more power than all of them combined.

So this is what it was.

Jin Taekyung gazed clearly—not with his eyes, but with his mind.

At himself, thoroughly bound and forced to his knees.

At the enormous Black Dragon looking down on him with haughty disdain.

And at this world, and the secrets it had hidden.

It was a sensation that had come to him after another life-or-death struggle, one he had already experienced once in the not-so-distant past.

“People often fail to believe the truth, even when it’s right in front of them, and pass it by. It’s truly a pity.”

The voice echoed from his memory, belonging to the old man who had served as his Helper in the Tutorial, the Martial God without equal in all history—or the savior of humanity.

“You saw what cannot be seen, and avoided what cannot be avoided. So why can’t you believe what you did yourself?”

In another space, one that existed in neither dream nor reality, the Absolute One had asked him that question.

Back then, Jin Taekyung hadn’t answered.

No—he couldn’t.

He had been caught in a sensation that ruled his body and flesh.

Just like now.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

He heard it, but didn’t hear it.

SYSTEM

Martial arts are built through endless training and pain, and perfected in battles fought on the brink between life and death.

Congratulations. The Fire Dragon Divine Spear has reached Great Completion.

You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP and Fame as a reward.

Level Up!

Status effect Trance applied.

He saw it, but didn’t see it.

No-self.

True to the meaning of those two characters, Jin Taekyung forgot everything.

His memories up to that point. The many emotions lurking like thorns in his mind and heart.

Even Jin Taekyung himself.

And yet his pupils, now tinged with a deep blue-black light, were reading everything in the world.

Mind’s Eye.

Feeling something he hadn’t experienced since that day, Jin Taekyung lifted his spear as if entranced.

Chapter 1167

It wasn’t a simple thrust.

More precisely, it was something beyond attack or defense.

Why should it be either?

The question surfaced through Jin Taekyung’s hazy consciousness. He tilted the White Flame’s spearhead, wreathed in blue-black fire, upward.

Toward the Dragon’s Breath pouring down to blanket the sky.

Like a fool trying to stop a waterfall with an umbrella that had no fabric.

Shh.

A movement so simple it could hardly be called a form.

But what that tiny movement did next was beyond even an Ancient Dragon of unprecedented power and knowledge to predict.

Rrrrrumble!

Morgoth’s pupils widened.

As time resumed its rapid flow, his eyes flew wide before he even realized it.

What is this…?!

It was splitting apart.

A massive pillar of magical power, several meters[3928] in diameter, was splitting into dozens of streams the moment it touched the spearhead.

Even now, it continued to split.

How is that possible?

Morgoth had lived for thousands of years.

Sometimes as a human, an elf, or a dwarf. Sometimes wearing the hide of a monster. He had enjoyed the pleasures only the strong could afford and amassed countless experiences and knowledge.

That was precisely why Morgoth found this all the harder to understand.

How was such a thing possible?

How could a human smaller than his claw read the flow of energy within Dragon Breath?

But Morgoth’s questions were no more than empty echoes.

Even Jin Taekyung, lost in Trance, couldn’t properly answer them.

No—his consciousness had retreated somewhere so deep and distant that he didn’t even know what he was doing.

He simply followed what he saw.

Rrrrrumble!

Dark. Pitch-black in every direction.

[3928] Several meters is roughly 10–20 ft.

A muffled roar filled his ears. The magical power diverted up, down, left, and right by the spearhead had unwittingly formed a rounded barrier around Jin Taekyung alone.

At least, that was how it looked from the outside.

Fwoooosh.

Why?

It was bright. Radiant.

Though darkness seemed to have swallowed the world, Jin Taekyung's blue-black eyes saw countless lights glittering before him.

Beautiful.

He gazed at the strands of color filling his vision.

Some were red, others blue.

Some shone a dazzling white. Others held a darkness so pure he couldn't fathom its depth.

The dozens of kinds of Magic that arrived a step behind the Breath were just like that.

Water, fire, ice, gusts of wind, lightning.

Each was powerful enough to kill thousands. All had been cast for one purpose: to erase a single person from this world. Jin Taekyung was grateful that person was him.

Had those spells been aimed at his allies instead, they would have died horribly.

Inventory open. Summon.

It all happened in an instant.

An old iron spear appeared in midair, and at the same moment, Jin Taekyung instinctively drew up the energy in his Middle Dantian.

Fwoosh!

It was swift and powerful.

More so than ever before since he had opened his Middle Dantian.

Wreathed in flame, the iron spear streaked through space like a bolt of lightning. It pierced the core of every spell in its path before finally losing all its power.

KABOOOOOM!

Sky and earth shook.

The spells, which had exploded before reaching their target, painted the sky in a dazzling display. Witnessing the unbelievable sight, the Black Dragon opened his enormous jaws wide.

He drew even more power from the vast magical force dormant within his Dragon Heart.

Rrrrrumble!

An immense pressure came through the spearhead.

And then, beneath the Dragon's Breath pouring down harder and harder without pause, Jin Taekyung raised the knee buried deep in the ground.

I have to get up.

One thought filled his mind.

He had to go. There was no other choice.

And for now, he could forget everything else.

The pain of his bones slipping out of place.

The horrifying mass of magical power that threatened to swallow his body and spearhead at any moment.

The thorny vines constricting his entire body, and the immense gravity pressing down on both shoulders.

Crack!

His foot came forward, as unsteady as a child taking its first step.

But as the deep footprint showed, Jin Taekyung's strength and Will carried more weight than ever before.

More than mere Magic could hold back.

Crack!

The thorny vines wrapped around him like chains tore apart, and the gravity that had weighed on him like a ten-thousand-geun[3929] boulder began to weaken.

Crack.

One step.

Crack.

Another.

Slowly, without hesitation, Jin Taekyung advanced.

Toward the enormous shadow in his dream-blurred vision, with the spearhead shining alone at the center of the pitch-black Breath to light his way like a torch.

And behind him stood a comrade willing to brave any danger for his sake.

"May the flames of hell consume our enemies—"

The Grand Mage's cry rang through the din like a roar.

Fwoooosh!

The sky flushed red. A dozen or so fireballs emerged from between the storm clouds and took aim at the Black Dragon's head.

"Hell Fire!"

Rrrrrumble!

The spell was complete. A fierce heat rushed in, scorching the sky.

But Morgoth wasn't even slightly startled by this sudden attack.

[3929] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to 600 g (1.32 lb). Ten thousand geun is 6,000 kg (about 13,000 lb).

No—when he saw that it was Magic, not a blade, coming for him, he sneered in anger.

He was no one but a Dragon.

Born of wonder, one of the species that ruled Magic—and once the Dragon Lord who had led all his kind from the highest place.

Disappear.

He didn't even need to speak.

Morgoth possessed a powerful will and magical power greater still. His Magic existed in a realm beyond the reach of any other species, humans included.

PAAAM!

Anti Magic.

The Dragon's magical power devoured the human's mana.

Ash and embers scattered through the air. Far away, Magic Johnson—who had risked intervening while fighting the Guardians—coughed up blood and fell to his knees.

Mana Backlash.

The deadliest injury a mage could suffer.

Yet a gentle smile had formed on the Grand Mage's blood-soaked lips.

Because the brief opening he had created gave someone else a chance, even if only for a moment, to escape the gravity.

"Go, Jin."

His lips barely moved around the faint words.

Fwoosh.

Flames surged from the tip of Jin Taekyung's foot as it touched down.

Heat strong enough to overcome the momentarily weakened gravity and carry him beyond the range of the Magic surrounding a radius of dozens of meters.[3930]

KABOOM!

Energy compressed, then exploded.

And then—

A charge.

Whooooosh!

Jin Taekyung raced forward, cutting through the Dragon Breath that stretched ahead in a single line.

The closer he came—and the more danger Morgoth sensed—the fiercer the Breath pouring toward the ground became. It didn't matter.

If anything, the rougher it grew, the more clearly he could follow the flow of its power.

[3930] Dozens of meters is roughly dozens of yards; 20–90 m is about 66–295 ft.

Leaving behind the countless roars and screams blanketing the battlefield.

Without a moment's hesitation, he pressed on. Forward, and farther forward.

At last, as the Dragon's enormous shadow loomed over him like a mountain, Jin Taekyung instinctively knew what he had to do.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear, Second Form.

Heavenly Strike.

Rrrrrumble!

No one there had ever seen anything like it.

The spearhead, wreathed in blue-black flame, rose through the colossal pillar of darkness, cleaving it in two.

Like a dragon soaring into the sky.

Becoming the fire dragon itself.

It all began and ended in an instant.

Fwoooosh!

The darkness scattered. The Dragon's Breath had finally spent its power.

And a human had done it.

As Morgoth watched the unbelievable sight, he wondered where it had all gone wrong.

Had the arrogance and complacency deep in his heart grown into a snowball large enough to come crashing down on him like this?

Or—

Had the strength and will of a mortal with barely a hundred years to live truly surpassed his own?

No. That can't be.

His name was Morgoth.

Master of the lofty Silver Mountains. Archduke of the Demon Realm.

The ancient Black Dragon muttered to himself, alone in the slowed world, and spread his enormous wings.

Then he dove toward the small figure shooting skyward once more, cutting through the heavens.

PAAAM!

Compressed air exploded.

From sky to ground.

From ground to sky.

Two shadows shot toward each other.

The Dragon’s claw, wrapped in pitch-black magical power, and the spearhead filled with blue-black fire tore through space.

As if they had lived for this moment alone.

“I—I…!”

Beyond the howling wind, Morgoth let out a fierce cry and put everything he had into a slash of his massive claw.

At that same instant, he realized something.

The foreleg he had just swung had already been cut by someone else.

And the wound remained even now, after he had returned to his true form.

The Skeleton King.

A shallow wound, but one that had never healed.

To some, he had been no more than a trophy. To someone else, he had been a friend. Perhaps it was Morgoth’s instinct that made him remember, at that very moment, the final trace of the Skeleton King’s stubborn resolve.

Perhaps.

Just perhaps.

The long game he had played for thousands of years might finally be coming to an end.

And ominous instincts were never wrong.

Shhk.

A low, sharp slicing sound.

The spearhead, carrying its wielder’s Will, cut into the last trace his friend had left behind.

Chapter 1168

It connected.

And it cut.

That was all.

The whole thing began and ended in an instant. There was nothing more to explain.

Jin Taekyung had never harbored a trace of doubt. The hellfire spearhead he drove forward without hesitation could melt and cleave through anything.

Even a Dragon's bone and hide.

Shhk.

A hair's breadth.

That was all the difference.

Yet that sliver of distance, shorter than a dagger, made a difference as vast and deep as the distance between heaven and earth.

The enormous claw barely grazed his Fire Dragon Armor. But the spearhead rose in a perfect arc and drove straight into the tiny wound etched into the Dragon's foreleg.

Fwoooosh!

Blood burst forth like a waterfall.

Strangely silver, the Dragon's blood flooded Jin Taekyung's vision. Its vicious acidity even began to melt his exposed skin and parts of his Fire Dragon Armor.

He didn't care.

No—he had no reason to.

Compared to everything that had happened and everything still to come, this much pain was nothing.

Grit.

Jin Taekyung clenched his teeth against the faint pain.

Planting a foot on the Dragon's foreleg beneath him like a stepping-stone, he drove his tightly clenched fist forward with all his strength.

Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist.

BAM!

Compressed air exploded from the fist he drove forward like lightning.

The fierce heat in his knuckles swallowed the spray of blood, opening a new path beyond it.

Whoooosh!

He charged.

One man staking everything on a charge, a storm of hellfire that would melt and devour anything in its way.

CRRRUNCH!

A trail of flame cut forward like an icebreaker smashing through a glacier.

The spearhead, buried deep in the enemy's flesh and bone, spewed lava as it climbed higher and higher.

Flames rose in the wake of Jin Taekyung's arrowing form, so vivid and fierce that they drew the eyes of everyone still locked in battle.

Human and monster alike.

Not one of them was an exception.

Without realizing it, they lowered the blades in their hands or hid their sharp claws and fangs.

Every living thing that had survived this horrific battlefield sensed it instinctively.

That rising flame, devouring space itself, would decide all their fates.

If there were any exceptions, they were the two beings who had faced only each other from the start.

Leaving the vast battlefield and its countless watching eyes behind, the Ancient Dragon and the human raced toward their final moment, gazing at each other like figures in a myth.

Jin Taekyung.

Morgoth.

The names passed between them without a sound—not from their mouths, but through their eyes across the open air.

They heard without hearing.

And without speaking, they felt.

And he could feel the emotions in the enemy's eyes as they drew closer like the wind, as though defying the slowing of time.

What Jin Taekyung saw now was a Dragon's eyes filled with terrible pain and fear.

Yeah. It hurts, doesn't it?

With a thought that would never reach Morgoth, Jin Taekyung put more strength into his charge.

He ran up the Dragon's long, massive foreleg like a flight of stairs, toward the head towering above him like a skyscraper.

Like it hurt the people you killed with your own hands. Or the ones who lost someone precious because of you.

Jin Taekyung suddenly wished Morgoth's pained roar—every emotion he felt, every ounce of his suffering—could reach them all.

Tens of millions had died.

Hundreds of millions had lost family, friends, and homes.

That was why Jin Taekyung couldn’t stop.

It was what fueled his will to keep moving forward.

CRRRUNCH!

Perhaps that was why his will surpassed the limits of his body.

Why the flame on his spearhead, weakening as the emptiness in his lower dantian grew, roared back to life. Why, even as the Dragon’s acidic blood melted away parts of his skin and muscle, he no longer felt the pain.

Whoooooom!

The sky suddenly darkened. Gusts slammed in from both sides.

Jin Taekyung didn’t waver.

He simply swept the spearhead that had been cutting through the enemy’s body upward, toward the two wings bearing down on him with enough force to crush a mountain.

Shhhh.

The rolling flames rose at an angle.

One line, chillingly swift and savage.

In the arc of blue-black fire that suddenly appeared in the air were the Dragon’s two wings, which had ruled the vast sky and blanketed the earth for thousands of years.

Shhk!

—Kraaaaaa!

The Dragon’s body thrashed with a muffled scream. Jin Taekyung pressed down on it and dug in his toes.

Fwoosh—BAM!

Flamefire Path.

Propelled upward by an explosion worthy of its name, his figure appeared in Morgoth’s pitch-black eyes.

No—that wasn’t right.

He soared into the sky like a fire dragon that had finally reached the time of its ascension. His form wasn’t merely reflected in those eyes; it overflowed from them.

—…!

Is this what it feels like when time stops?

In that strange sensation, with every sound and movement around him gone, Morgoth watched Jin Taekyung.

He saw eyes sunk to unfathomable depths, their blue-black light unlike anything he had ever seen. He felt the countless fragments of emotion within them.

And, a step too late, he understood.

Too late.

Morgoth couldn’t tell whether reason or instinct had reached that conclusion. But one thing was certain.

In this world where everything had stopped, the spearhead slowly descending toward him was the only thing that moved. No ability he possessed could stop it or evade it.

That left him one path.

—Kraaaaaa!

His enormous jaws gaped open.

In the Ancient Dragon’s last, death-defying struggle, the immense magical power and countless teeth lurking within his maw flashed toward a single human.

And at that very moment—

Rrrrk.

Jin Taekyung gripped the spear shaft with all the strength he had left.

Muscles swelled throughout his body. Fire raced through hundreds of acupoints and spread to every limb and bone.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

His heart hammered furiously.

His lower dantian was so empty that the recovery he’d gained from leveling up might as well never have happened. His mind, pushed far beyond its limits, had been crying out with exhaustion for some time.

But he didn’t stop.

More precisely, he had no reason to.

I can see it.

In this new world painted with lines of every color, one trajectory shone brighter than all the rest.

Following the path he had read through the Mind’s Eye, Jin Taekyung poured all his strength and will into the spearhead.

Fwoosh—

As time began to move again, the flame on the spearhead wavered.

But it wasn’t a sign of danger. It was a change—and an evolution—that took place in an instant.

Shhhh.

The wavering flame gathered into one.

It came together and connected, no longer a flame but a single line, as though it had become the spearhead itself. Then, at last, it settled.

One step beyond fire’s innate savagery lay hellfire refined to the utmost degree.

It was a peak Jin Taekyung had reached through his own enlightenment. A third path no one had ever taught him.

Fire Dragon Divine Spear.

Third Form.

Fwoooosh.

Space twisted.

The spearhead, raised as though to cleave the sky, and the refined flame within it gave off a terrifying heat.

Like another sun prepared to bring forth a new sky.

Open Heaven.

A fierce shiver seized Jin Taekyung's body and mind. With a roar that made no sound, he brought down the hellfire spearhead.

KABOOOOOM!

The blue-black sun opened a world drowned in darkness.

They heard it, but didn't hear it.

They saw it, but didn't see it.

Amid mountains of corpses and rivers of blood, countless living creatures watched an unbelievable sight unfold in the distance. In that moment, they all felt the same thing.

A shudder.

They shuddered.

A flash too bright to look at filled their vision. A muffled roar blocked their ears. Yet every survivor could feel it clearly.

This long and terrible battle had finally come to an end.

As the light slowly faded, what emerged beyond it proved them right.

Fwoooosh.

A fierce wind swept through, wrapping around the enormous body as it fell, silver blood spraying from it like a waterfall.

Yes. It was a fall.

And with it came the downfall of an Ancient Dragon who had lived for thousands of years.

What falls has wings. But his wings would never take flight again.

KABOOOOOM!

The earth shook. Dust billowed up and swept across the area like a desert sandstorm.

Yet tens of thousands of eyes that had witnessed it all remained fixed on the sky.

More precisely, on the one figure moving through the terrible stillness weighing down on the world.

Step.

He walked slowly through the air as though climbing down an invisible staircase.

Even from a distance, he looked utterly exhausted. But no one there dared entertain the thought, or feel anything of the sort.

With the sky—its clouds torn away without a trace—at his back, he descended toward the ground against the falling sun. His very presence inspired an overwhelming awe.

As if he were something beyond human.

Or a glimpse of someone the world would remember forever, as that person had once been.

"…Sky."

The breathless murmur escaped someone's lips. Watching Jin Taekyung with trembling eyes, the others remembered one important thing they had forgotten.

They had won.

They—

No. Humanity had won.

And the one who had led them was a new savior of humanity.

Chapter 1169

The Dragon’s roar, which had pierced the clouds and shaken the sky, was gone. So were the two wings that had cast an immense shadow over the earth.

Yet there wasn’t the slightest emptiness in the endless sky.

If anything, it overflowed.

With the presence of a single being.

Another Dragon—the one who had brought the first crashing down.

“Jin!”

It happened in an instant.

The Grand Mage’s shout, amplified by Magic, swept across the battlefield. A moment later, tens of thousands of voices joined as one.

“Jin! Jin! Jin!”

As if they’d made a promise, they cried out with all their might.

They staunched the bleeding from severed arms and hauled their blood-soaked bodies upright.

They stared at the man walking down through the distant sky and shouted the name of the savior who had dragged from the heavens the evil Dragon that had nearly plunged the world into ruin.

Clang, clang, clang!

Countless spears and swords swayed like a forest in the wind, then surged toward the enemy like a wave.

Shhk! Krrrrrrunch!

The two waves that had surged toward each other, roiling with thick killing intent, were gone.

There were only humans advancing and monsters being swept away.

And amid that enormous scream and roar that shook heaven and earth, the clear sound of a bell rang in one man’s ear.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

SYSTEM

The fire dragon raises its tail and sweeps the earth (□□□□), then shakes the open sky (□□), and a new heaven shall open (□□).

You have forged your own path through deep insight into the Fire Dragon Divine Spear.

A new form has been added to the Supreme Peak martial art Fire Dragon Divine Spear. Its power and underlying principles have grown stronger.

Third Form, Open Heaven, has been registered. It will be recorded in the history of the Fire Gate Clan, and future generations will remember your name and your achievement.

You have accomplished the remarkable feat Learn from the Old, Know the New!

Your understanding of the Fire Gate Clan's martial arts has deepened. When using related martial arts, you can direct qi more freely and consume less internal energy.

The realm of Flamefire Path has increased!

The realm of Flame Divine Palm has increased!

...

...

...

Congratulations. Fire Gate Divine Technique and Qi Sense have reached the ninth star!

This is both a stairway to a new realm and a massive wall blocking your path. May martial fortune be with you.

You have gained insight into Mind's Eye. This ability activates only when certain conditions are met and causes extreme fatigue.

You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP and Fame.

Level Up!

Level Up!

All injuries have been healed as a result of leveling up.

Status effect Trance has been lifted.

The moment the last holographic window appeared in his blurry vision—

Squish.

Jin Taekyung's foot came down on the ground, soaked in someone's blood, as he stumbled forward as if about to collapse.

Sssssss.

Thick steam rose in the wake of his staggering steps.

But he knew that even blood this fiercely acidic could no longer harm a single hair on his head.

So did the owner of the silver blood flowing like a small river.

“Morgoth.”

At Jin Taekyung’s quiet voice, the Ancient Dragon’s eyelids, shut without so much as a twitch, slowly lifted.

“You’re late. Why did you take so long?”

His breath came raggedly, and his upper body had half melted away.

Between the cracks in his chest lay a large black jewel.

No—a Dragon Heart.

Despite Morgoth’s calm tone, he was in a ghastly state. Jin Taekyung dropped down beside him.

“I was tired. Thanks to someone.”

That was neither a lie nor an exaggeration.

Though he’d completely shattered the Dragon’s Breath, the force of its aftermath had destroyed his divine weapon, the Fire Dragon Armor. And the mental exhaustion that had built up throughout the battle was beyond imagining.

It would have been no surprise if he lost consciousness then and there.

If leveling up hadn’t healed his body, Morgoth wouldn’t have been the only one lying here.

“Lucky for me.”

“Luck.”

Morgoth murmured the word to himself and studied Jin Taekyung with his enormous eyes.

His clothes hung in tatters, leaving him nearly half-naked, and blood and dust covered his body.

But that was only his outward appearance. The skin visible through the rags was as smooth as a newborn’s.

Though Morgoth couldn’t sense even the slightest trace of healing magic.

“I don’t think luck alone explains it.”

“I was born with heaven-sent luck.”

“Are you sure?”

“What do you mean?”

“That doesn’t quite sound right. Perhaps…”

With his gaze turned toward the sky steeped in sunset, Morgoth continued.

“Divine favor. That might be the most accurate way to put it.”

“…!”

“You can use subspace freely without ever learning a single spell, let alone becoming a Grand Mage. And healing power like that… Yes. It’s hard to explain without divine favor.”

For a moment, Jin Taekyung fell silent.

God.

Ever since that blisteringly hot summer several years ago, when he’d obtained the capsule and woken in Murim, God had seemed both closer to him and farther away than anything else.

That one word, surfacing so suddenly in a conversation he’d never expected, disturbed his thoughts like a rock thrown into a still lake.

Before he could steady himself from the confusion that had seized him for just an instant, Morgoth continued.

“Do you believe in God?”

Morgoth asked the rigid Jin Taekyung without warning, then went on without waiting for an answer.

“I do. I always have.”

Of course he did.

Morgoth had always thought that he himself was practically a blessing from God.

A lifespan approaching immortality. Immense power granted at birth.

That was what Dragons were, and even among them, Morgoth stood apart.

Perhaps that was why the greatest scholar, warrior, and mage of any race on the continent had sought to draw closer to God.

“Every desire I pursued, every pleasure I sought—all of it was for that alone.”

Now Morgoth confessed without holding anything back.

His entire life had served a single purpose: to meet the absolute being who had created humans, elves, dwarves, and even monsters.

“So much time has passed in vain. Before I knew it, I had become a being who was everywhere and nowhere. Much like the God I’d sought for so long.”

He had been a creator and destroyer of the world, and a wanderer through it.

He had founded an empire that ruled the entire continent, then broken it into pieces. He had lived as a member of every race in the world, learning their ways and their rules.

But God never appeared.

Not even when the greatest of God’s creations, pursuing the faintest clue, reached into the realm of an unforgivable taboo.

“That was how I left for the Demon Realm. No—I suppose it would be more accurate to say I met him. As it happened, he was on his way to my homeland, too.”

“If you mean him—”

“Asmodeus. The most cursed demon since the heavens opened and the earth awoke. The most terrible nightmare, and the ruler of the Demon Realm.”

“…!”

“We fought, and he won. I was crushed by helplessness and defeat unlike anything I’d ever known.”

But even in the humiliation he felt for the first time in his life, Morgoth found the answer to a question.

“Before I met Asmodeus, a thought occurred to me. If I couldn’t find God anywhere in the land where I’d lived for thousands of years, perhaps God existed in another world, in a form I’d never expected.”

Morgoth had been wrong.

Demon King Asmodeus was unquestionably a powerful being beyond Morgoth’s reach, but he could never be called a god.

“In the end, I had to continue my long journey. Even if it meant burning my homeland and striking down my own kind under Asmodeus, of all beings.”

Jin Taekyung’s eyes trembled as he listened to the story drift by like the wind. The old Dragon didn’t miss it.

“You won’t understand. Perhaps no one would. But I had a goal I absolutely had to achieve. I believed I’d been born for it.”

And so Morgoth survived.

Though he had been the Dragon Lord, he killed dozens of his own kind and took their hearts. With the power he gained, he became the Archduke of the Demon Realm, second only to Asmodeus.

A long time passed again. Then he heard news that was hard to believe.

“A mere human defeated Asmodeus? At first, I didn’t even find it funny.”

But it was true.

Some of the monsters who had returned to the Demon Realm through the Gates relayed everything they had seen and heard. Soon everyone in the Demon Realm plunged into utter chaos—everyone except Morgoth.

He thrilled at the news.

In another world, one he hadn’t known existed, someone had appeared who had defeated Asmodeus—the being closer to God than any Morgoth had ever encountered.

The astonishing news was enough to revive his interest, slowly worn down beneath the weight of years piled up like dust.

And at last, the Ancient Dragon’s long-held wish had been answered.

Right here, today.

“It was the first time. In all the thousands of years I’d watched the order of things remain unchanged, you were the first being I’d seen defy it.”

At that moment—

Pop.

The Skeleton King's head appeared out of nowhere and dropped into Jin Taekyung's arms as though nestling against him.

"Jin Taekyung. Great human hero. No…"

Morgoth's body edged closer to death, but his voice and gaze shone more vividly than ever.

"You who were chosen by God."

Chapter 1170

The relief of finally getting the Skeleton King back lasted only a moment.

Jin Taekyung's eyes darkened at the words that came through the Dragon's bloodied teeth.

"I was chosen by God?"

Morgoth gave a dry laugh at the question, spoken almost to himself.

"If you're asking me, that's foolish."

"What does that—"

"Jin Taekyung, I don't know everything about you. I can only guess. Even Asmodeus, who brought countless worlds to their knees with his immense power, would be no different. He may be omnipotent, but he is not omniscient."

Of course.

Omniscient and omnipotent described only one being.

God.

A being nowhere to be seen, yet present everywhere.

One who knew all things and could do all things.

But Morgoth was looking not at the sky, but at Jin Taekyung.

At a human wearing the shadow of the God he had spent thousands of years searching for like a cloak.

"Ask yourself, not me. The answer is there."

"…!"

Jin Taekyung's eyes trembled. His body went rigid.

He gave no answer.

No—he couldn't answer.

A shiver raced up his spine as a wave of memories swept over him without warning.

Asmodeus is dead. On the day I was born. The day of our victory.

At the heart of the enormous temple built in the desert, the Jin Taekyung of the past spoke through gritted teeth to the enemy before him.

He was erased, and we won. That's all. That's the truth.

The hoarse voice coming from his lips sounded strange, as if it belonged to someone else.

Watching him, the monster of the abyss—the Doppelganger—smiled.

That is also true, Jin Taekyung, chosen one. It must be all you know, and the truth as you understand it.

Chosen one.

When Jin Taekyung first heard those strange words from the Doppelganger, he had no idea he would soon hear them again from someone he never expected.

So it was you.

In the imperial palace's grand banquet hall, covered in the rebels' blood and corpses, the Bow Saint finally revealed her identity and spoke.

The chosen one the Martial God spoke of.

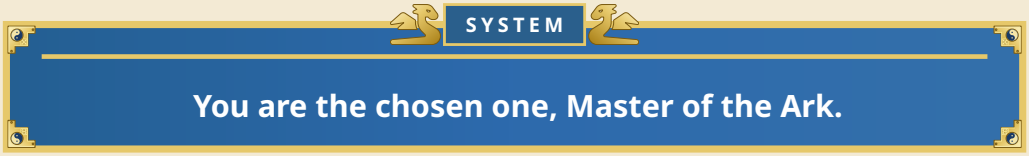
Right.

This wasn't the first time.

The Doppelganger. The Bow Saint. The Martial God, who had left her a letter.

Even the System had called him the chosen one.

On the very day he erased the Doppelganger.



Remembering that brief System message, Jin Taekyung looked at Morgoth.

More precisely, at his own reflection in the Dragon's enormous eye.

"You're right."

Though exhaustion weighed on his body, his eyes shone more clearly than ever.

Jin Taekyung continued, as if whispering to himself.

"Maybe… I already knew the answer."

He'd always wondered where this incredible power he'd acquired one day had come from, and who had given it to him.

But he'd kept denying it. Doubting it.

Why him?

Of all the billions of people in the world, why had an insignificant F-rank Hunter been chosen?

If such an omniscient and omnipotent God truly existed, why hadn't He personally stopped the countless tragedies and disasters that had happened?

But the instant Morgoth turned the question back on him, he understood why he'd kept looking away from a truth so plain before his eyes.

"It was too much. Everything I had to carry, every moment."

His father's untimely death. The family he left behind. A life that could continue only by standing on someone else's sacrifice.

The burdens took different forms, but they weighed the same.

Each one pressed down on his body and mind like a mountain.

"Maybe that's why I came to resent God."

"Resent Him?"

Morgoth laughed at the unexpected answer, bloody phlegm rattling in his throat.

“Interesting. You, who should be more grateful to Him than anyone?”

“I’ve lost too much for that. Things that mattered more than anything.”

“You gained things, too. They must have mattered to you.”

“Yeah. And the more they matter, the heavier they are. Now they’re almost too much to bear.”

“Do you really think so?”

“You don’t know me. You know even less about humans.”

“No. I know them well. Perhaps better than any of you.”

With that calm reply, Morgoth looked out at the world sinking into the colors of sunset.

“This place is certainly different. It’s nothing like the world where I was born and raised.”

Of course it was.

This strange world called Earth had neither three moons and a sun, nor twelve continents and nine seas.

Nor did it have great cities built and sustained entirely by magic, or vividly colored wilderness teeming with spirits.

There were no other races living across the world, each guarding its own territory.

If the disaster called the Great Cataclysm hadn’t brought such enormous changes, the contrast would have been even starker.

“But I found one exception. Even if Asmodeus had never invaded this world, that one thing would have remained the same.”

Jin Taekyung suddenly realized what Morgoth was about to say.

“Humans.”

“Yes. You humans. The weakest and most foolish beings of all the races I’ve seen and known. That was what I found so strange.”

Looking straight at Jin Taekyung, Morgoth added,

“Even in the world I left long ago, humans were always the rulers.”

“…!”

“At first, I couldn’t understand it. Your lifespans and wisdom couldn’t match the elves. You weren’t physically gifted like the dwarves, and you didn’t even have the reproductive capacity of monsters.”

And yet, humans had thrived in Morgoth’s homeland.

The civilization they built was so dazzling that no race except the Dragons could match it. The fame of their extraordinary mages and knights had crossed the seas and shaken every continent.

The race Morgoth had thought inferior in every way had seized dominion over a world.

After a longer period of study and amusement than any before it, he had finally found an answer.

"Desire. You humans are made of endless desire. That's why you keep changing."

He had found the answer, but he still couldn't understand it.

Humans were that complicated.

When they were weak, they banded together as if they'd made a pact. Once their groups grew large, they split apart again and again.

Even after gaining more than enough, they continued to fight.

To capture beautiful elves and enslave them.

To plunder the dwarves' mines, where gold and treasure lay.

To use monster parts to study Magic and make sharper, sturdier weapons.

They even fought to kill their own kind and take their land.

They didn't fight to survive. They bled and died to gain something more.

Desire had turned to greed.

"But not all humans were like that. If some were ruled by instincts uglier than a monster's, there were others at the opposite extreme."

The eyes that had once glinted like obsidian had long since lost their light.

Morgoth looked at Jin Taekyung, his vision slowly fading.

"Like you."

"…What are you trying to say?"

"You're human, too. You have desires rooted deep in your heart, and you must have kept changing to fulfill them, whether you wanted to or not."

"That's—"

Jin Taekyung fell silent.

Everything Morgoth said was true.

At first, he'd simply wanted to get stronger.

He'd wanted to break free of the limits placed on him, earn more money and fame, and become a son and older brother his family could be proud of.

But by the time he realized it, everything had changed.

And he'd taken on an enormous responsibility he had never imagined—could never have imagined—just two years earlier.

Then how have I managed to bear all this until now?

This time, too, the answer was close at hand.

I changed, too. Enough to bear the responsibility as it kept getting heavier. I kept changing.

And the world called that something else. Not change.

Growth.

He had grown, and he was still growing.

A child had become a boy, a boy had become a young man—and before he knew it, a torch lighting the way for all humanity. A new savior.

That was why what Jin Taekyung held deep in his heart was the purest of desires, and at the same time, something beyond the word desire.

“Hope.”

In that moment, Morgoth could feel it.

The power and bright vitality in the word that had passed through those parched lips.

“Hope. Is that the answer you found?”

Jin Taekyung shook his head.

“That’s what I thought. But it wasn’t.”

“Then?”

“I’d just forgotten it for a while. I was so overwhelmed that struggling through one suffocating moment after another was all I could manage.”

That was exactly it.

He hadn’t found hope. He had remembered it.

A feeling he’d forgotten somewhere along the way.

Though everyone looked at him and thought of hope, Jin Taekyung himself hadn’t felt at ease for a single moment.

Because he was the torch.

He had to press forward alone at the very front, fighting the deepest darkness.

But not anymore.

Jin Taekyung hoped more fervently than ever. He wished and prayed.

That he would survive to the end alongside those who were fighting even now, shouting his name.

And that this goddamn story would, please, have a happy ending.

“Honestly, I don’t care who chose me. Even if it was all a delusion or a misunderstanding.”

Using his spear as a cane, Jin Taekyung pushed his exhausted body to its feet.

“I’ve made it this far, and I’ll see it through.”

Shing.

The spearhead flashed in the sunset, its edge as keen as ever—like its master’s unwavering will.

“One question.”

“You may ask.”

“Why?”

The question was brief, but Morgoth knew what Jin Taekyung meant.

Why had he given back the Skeleton King so readily?

Why speak and act this way toward the one who was about to end his life of thousands of years?

To Morgoth, though, the answer was obvious. Simple.

“Because if you become even a little stronger, what comes next will be more interesting.”

“What?”

Morgoth laughed aloud at Jin Taekyung’s stiff-faced reply.

There was a longing for amusement in that laugh, a longing he couldn’t give up even with death before him. And there was mockery of himself.

Yes, Asmodeus. Now I understand why you summoned me to this world.

He had realized it far too late, but this was enough.

He had seen a being who stood outside the ordained order and confirmed the existence of a human chosen by God.

And—

That thing around his neck… Yes. There’s no mistaking it.

Morgoth had caught a clear glimpse of something through the tatters of Jin Taekyung’s clothes.

He could sense it just as clearly.

A mysterious energy, neither mana nor magical power, enveloped it completely.

How fortunate. At least I could confirm a trace of that person.

As those words faded into emptiness within him, Morgoth gathered the last of his strength and opened his mouth.

“Now, shall we begin a new amusement?”

In that instant—

Shwaa!

The dazzling sunset shattered along the streak of light shooting toward the Dragon Heart.

Chapter 1171

It was like a jewel.

A jewel of such beauty and mystery that no work of art in the world—not even all of them combined—could compare.

But the thing casting its ominously dark light in every direction was no mere mineral.

Dragon Heart.

Just as its name implied, it was the heart and source of power of the mighty race known as Dragons.

And now, the Dragon Lord who had been wiser and more powerful than any since heaven and earth were divided—and who had fallen deeper into corruption than any other Dragon—knew his long life had come to an end.

He felt it in his body. In his soul.

And heard it in the sound ringing through his ears like thunder.

Crack.

Hairline fractures spread across the smooth surface like a spiderweb.

The Dragon Heart had barely held its shape through its master's fierce will and the last of his strength. Now nothing could stop the cracks.

There was only a streak of light to hasten the destruction already waiting for it.

Crunch!

It broke. Split apart.

The sunset light flowing along the spearhead, and the Dragon's heart that had never allowed another's touch.

Rumble.

Darkness gushed out in place of blood.

The air trembled, as if the world itself knew what was about to happen.

Yet even as his life faded, the Demon Dragon never took his eyes off the Divine Dragon who had driven a spearhead into his heart.

"Fight with all the strength you've been given. Keep surpassing yourself. Keep struggling."

There was no regret, anger, or curse in the words he murmured.

They were encouragement his listener could not understand, and a deep wistfulness at the astonishing amusement he would not live to see.

"…So I can see it from wherever I am."

At that moment—

Rumble.

Everything in the area stopped moving.

The wind. The air.

Even the Dragon's enormous body, now that it had breathed its last after a life beyond imagining.

And then—

Whoooooom!

The Dragon Heart overflowed, spilling the millennia of time and nearly infinite magical power stored within it in every direction.

Darkness and brilliance were words that should never belong together.

But in that moment, everyone on the battlefield saw and felt them both:

A pillar of dazzling darkness surging skyward, and an enormous power erupting with enough force to shake the world.

And the first to feel it, closer than anyone else, was naturally Jin Taekyung.

Whoosh—

The instant pitch-black darkness swallowed his vision, there was no time to think.

Jin Taekyung moved on instinct alone.

He pulled his spearhead from the Dragon's heart, tucked the Skeleton King's head —recovered at last—deep against his chest, and curled up like a fetus.

The next instant, a wave of magical power tore through the brief silence and crashed over him.

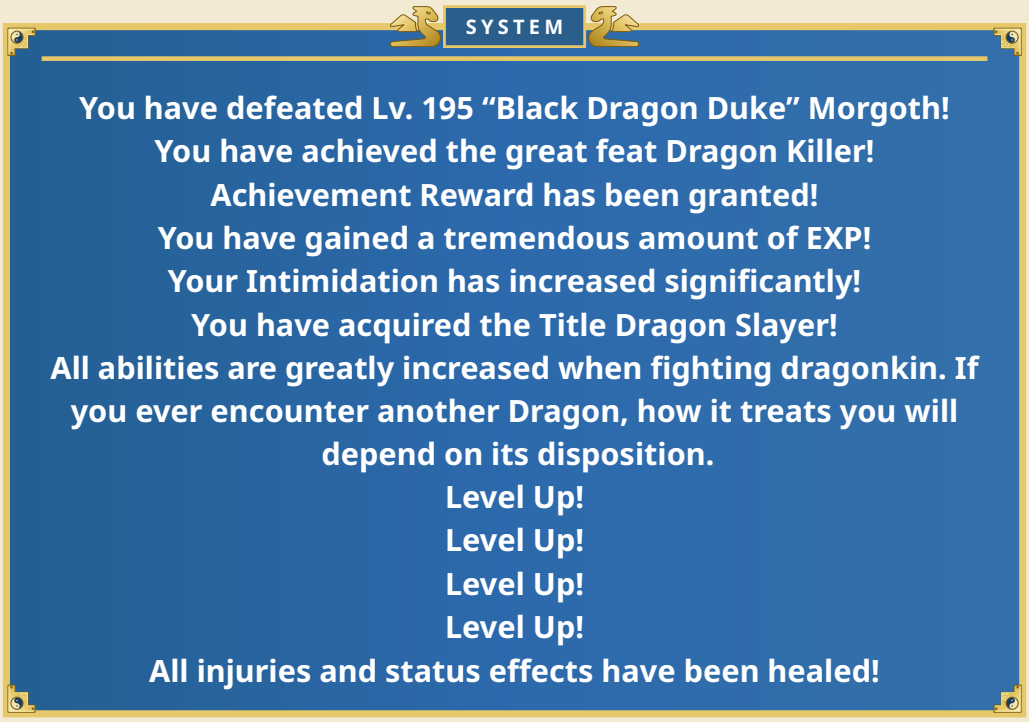
Rumble, rumble!

A deafening roar filled his ears, and the world turned upside down.

Sky and earth spun past his eyes again and again. A sensation of weightlessness took hold of his entire body.

Yet Jin Taekyung stayed conscious through the chaos, thanks to his own fierce will —and the clear chime that even the roar could not drown out.

Ding. Ding. Ding.



System notifications.

The surest proof that he had survived yet another crisis.

Maybe that was why Jin Taekyung was finally ready to let go of the thread of consciousness he had been clinging to with all his strength.

I want to rest.

That was all he could think about.

He didn’t care what happened next.

His body was still hurtling into the distance like a cannonball, but what did that matter?

Morgoth was dead. His vast monster army had been shattered and reduced to prey.

Even if Jin slammed into something and broke a few bones, he would be fine.

No—he might not even feel pain.

If he closed his eyes now, he would fall straight into a sleep deep enough to ignore any physical pain.

Everything was over. Nothing stood between him and rest.

Right. Nothing.

At least, Jin Taekyung was sure of that until, just before his terribly heavy eyelids fell shut, he heard a voice beside his ear.

“Damn it. This is awful.”

At first, he thought he had imagined it.

Or perhaps the rushing wind had made him hear things.

But neither was true.

He wasn’t asleep yet, and the voice that followed was so clear it proved all of this was real.

“Of all places to wake up, it had to be in the arms of a man reeking of sweat.”

The gruffness of that voice only made it more welcome. Jin Taekyung forced his eyes open with every ounce of strength he had.

He stared blankly at the speaker, who had somehow awakened in his arms. Then he opened his mouth.

“You can’t smell anything. You’re undead.”

“…You bastard.”

A brief silence, then a single curse.

But laughter slipped through the words, and the golden energy tracing the brow of the pure-white skull burned like a torch.

It fed on the Dragon’s magical power overflowing all around them and blazed more fiercely than ever.

Whoosh!

In an instant, the thick darkness spreading on the wind shot toward Jin Taekyung.

No—the being in his arms was drawing it in.

As rain awakens life, the sun lends it strength, and the soil nourishes its growth.

Fwoosh.

The more darkness seeped in, the clearer the golden energy became.

Beyond those two contrasting streams of color, a shadow steadily grew.

No one had ever seen anything like it.

Regeneration. Resurrection.

Perhaps even a new birth.

But the thing that grew by devouring all the darkness around it was no ominous presence.

Even if someone else might point at him and curse him, Jin Taekyung would never see him that way.

He shone as brightly as the radiant golden crown above him.

Rustle.

Jin Taekyung blinked.

His view had stopped spinning. The wind that had whipped past like blades was gone.

Through his dreamlike, hazy consciousness, he could make out only the familiar touch of someone carefully laying him on the ground, and a single line of text hovering above that person’s head.

Lv. 180 “Lord of the Dead” Undead King

The friend he had met again after a brief farewell had changed a little. Jin Taekyung let out a hollow laugh at the sight, remembering the day they had joined forces to defeat the Arch Lich.

"You've grown a lot, Bones."

The Skeleton—or rather, the Undead King—replied as casually as ever to words that still stood clear in his memory.

"Well, I was always a little taller."

"Bullshit."

"Now, now. How vulgar."

Then the two friends burst out laughing as if they had planned it.

Neither knew exactly what the other had been through while they were apart. But they knew one thing for certain.

They had trusted each other and fought to protect what they held dear.

"Human."

"What?"

"You've been through a lot."

Had he finally reached his limit? His friend's voice sounded as distant as an echo. Jin Taekyung answered faintly.

"…Yeah. You too."

Rest easy.

Ordinarily, Jin Taekyung would have grumbled, *What, is someone dying?* But he had nothing left.

Rest easy.

That short, tempting offer was more powerful than Morgoth's magic, and his exhausted mind was already poised to defy his will.

Thump.

His head drooped, and his eyelids shut tight. The Undead King watched as his friend sank into a deep sleep, as if he'd passed out the instant the words were spoken.

Then he murmured, as if to himself, the words he hadn't quite been able to add.

"…Though it'll be far too short a rest to rest easy."

If Jin Taekyung's mind had held out just a little longer, he would have understood exactly what those words meant.

No—he surely would have realized it himself, without being told.

The Jin Taekyung he knew had power and instincts every bit as remarkable as his foul temper.

But the massive Grand Mage who had drawn close without anyone noticing was also, without question, one of the most extraordinary people alive.

"Why? Why on earth?"

His voice shook with confusion. So did his eyes.

Magic Johnson dragged his battered body forward, looking around as if entranced.

The joy of reunion and victory had long since left his mind.

He had come to check on Jin Taekyung, but the ominous pulse of power from every direction had made him forget why he was there.

Rumble.

Magic Johnson gritted his teeth.

As a mage who had reached such heights, he could sense it all the more clearly: energy as dark as it was boundless, thick and clinging as a swamp.

Magical power.

So pure and dense that it brought back the decades-old memory of the Great Cataclysm at its height. It was saturating everything around him.

"…Dragon Heart."

Humanity's last Grand Mage trembled before he knew it. He understood the cause.

The Undead King had absorbed a vast amount of magical power, yet beside this nearly infinite source, that amount was nothing.

But the thought that had suddenly occurred to Magic Johnson was darker and more ominous than the magical power the Dragon Heart continued to pour out.

"Surely…?"

"Yes."

The Undead King tried to sound calm, but fear crept into his voice as he watched the darkness swell.

"It's begun. No—to be precise, it's complete."

He was right.

This was the final piece of the enormous puzzle. The key.

The death of the greatest and most powerful Dragon had completed the beginning of another catastrophe.

Beep.

A cold mechanical tone rang out, audible only to the chosen—yet, at this moment, reaching no one.

Rumble, rumble!

With a tremendous roar that shook the world, the pillar of magical power connecting heaven and earth exploded.

Like an active volcano with all its preparations complete.

Chapter 1172

“Active volcano” was no exaggeration.

If anything, it fell woefully short.

From the moment the last breath of the evil Dragon that had terrorized the whole world for thousands of years dispersed, an unstoppable catastrophe had been racing along its predetermined course.

An eruption—or an explosion.

It didn’t matter what you called it.

As if this were all it had left to do, the Dragon Heart slipped beyond its master’s control for the first time and vomited everything it had accumulated over untold ages into the world.

Using the body of the Dragon that had finally met its end as kindling, it raged more fiercely than a newly awakened active volcano.

Roooar!

Before the deafening roar that shook heaven and earth even reached their ears, everyone on the battlefield felt its terrifying shock wave.

The S-rank Hunters gathering the bodies of the seven Guardians who had found peace with Morgoth’s death—no, their former comrades.

The thousands of Hunters pursuing monsters that had lost the will to fight and scattered in every direction.

At that enormous, instinct-stirring rumble, they all turned their heads in the same direction as if on cue. Then they froze like statues.

Fwoooosh.

A chilling cold carried on the wind. A dark, ashen mist.

And beyond it, a towering pillar of pitch-black darkness, vast beyond comprehension.

“What is that…?”

The groan that slipped from someone’s lips spoke for everyone staring at the scene in stunned disbelief.

The evil Dragon—Morgoth—was dead. Of that there was no doubt.

They had won here today. The immediate danger was gone.

So why?

Why did that deep, pitch-black darkness feel more frightening than the unprecedented monster that had split the sky and poured its deathly breath down upon the earth?

They already knew the answer.

Their senses and minds, frozen by the icy magical power, simply hadn't responded quickly enough to the memory of *that day*—the day that had arrived without a word of warning just a few decades ago.

But two beings recognized what was happening before anyone else, and more clearly.

"…We have to stop it."

The Lord of the Dead spoke to the Grand Mage, who was muttering as though possessed by something unseen, his voice vacant.

"We can't stop it."

Unlike Magic Johnson's, the Undead King's tone was calm.

As if he'd already given up on everything.

But he hadn't.

There was still hope in his words, however faint—a tiny ember that had yet to lose its light.

"At least, not right now."

Holding his unconscious friend in his arms, the Undead King felt warmth against his fingertips as he spoke softly.

That was right.

Their hope hadn't gone out yet.

And protecting that ember was the best they could do now.

"We're leaving. Right now."

Before something happened that couldn't be undone.

Unable to force out the words that had risen to his throat, the Undead King turned away with Magic Johnson.

The sky above them was no longer filled with mere storm clouds. It was turning to pure darkness, casting a cold shadow over them.

The Great Cataclysm.

The ominous name humanity had forgotten over the past few decades was branded into everyone's minds once more.

And even after the Grand Mage's large-scale Warp Magic Formation appeared and vanished in a dazzling flash, a hard mechanical beep—one that hadn't reached its owner—continued to ring out somewhere in the world.

Beep.

SYSTEM

The distribution and concentration of magical power are skyrocketing. Take action immediately.
Current Rift Progress: 73%
When the Rift reaches a certain level, the ferocity and strength of monsters increase significantly.
Current Rift Progress: 85%
When the Rift reaches a certain level, the danger posed by Gates and the probability of a Monster Wave increase significantly.
Current Rift Progress: 90%

.
.
.

SYSTEM

You have failed to meet the Quest success requirements.
Mission: Defeat "Black Dragon Duke" Morgoth (Complete)
Halt the Rift's progress (Incomplete)
Main Quest Rift and Collapse has failed.
A new Main Quest, The Foreordained Collapse, has been created.
Good luck.

The System never lied.

And even people who didn't know it existed had no need for its warning messages. The changes were dramatic enough on their own.

Or like a marauder who barged in without warning.

"The magical power levels…! They're skyrocketing!"

"It's not just the Moscow area! St. Petersburg and Novosibirsk—and even the Kazan region…!"

Like waves crashing into one another, panicked shouts from all directions swallowed each other up.

Eyes webbed with red veins. Veins bulging along people's necks.

The pit of this dreadful chaos wasn't confined to any one place.

It was unfolding in underground bunkers around the world, where the people who ran entire nations had gathered; in cabinet meeting rooms; and, on a smaller scale, anywhere with an internet connection.

The Hunters still on the battlefield weren't the only ones who witnessed the unbelievable phenomenon.

When a spearhead wreathed in flames cut through Morgoth and the thick storm clouds covering Moscow's sky, billions of people had been given a brief chance to watch a battle that would decide their fate.

They shuddered at the sight of the evil Dragon falling, then cheered the young hero who had saved them once again.

But humanity didn't know that the single ray of light shining on them in their deepest despair would fade before the tears they shed had even dried.

Rumble.

Those watching the unstable, grainy feed transmitted from a satellite suddenly realized something was wrong.

A gigantic pillar spewed darkness so vivid it looked unnatural, like a black hole sucking everything in.

That was all they saw.

A blinding, oppressive beam of light—though light seemed impossible to associate with that darkness—closed the sky. This time, it never opened again.

And the darkness that had swallowed Moscow began to multiply.

Roooar.

Like a horse galloping across the wilderness, the darkness raced silently through a world gone quiet.

East, west, south, north.

Wherever its hooves passed, the light vanished.

Just as it had blotted out the sunset over Moscow, the darkness devoured every light.

Even the blazing sun couldn't pierce the darkness. No—the pure, profound magical power. The stars in the sky vanished, too.

By the time the Dragon Heart had poured out all its strength and crumbled to dust, the catastrophe now in full bloom had already scattered its spores across the world.

Just like now.

"Code Red! Code Red! Mutated Gate detected!"

"Mutated Gate? Shit, you're calling that Code Red? Report only Monster Waves!"

The superior's bark was understandable.

A few years ago, a Mutated Gate would have covered the front page of morning papers and dominated every breaking-news broadcast. Now the situation was so urgent that even that had become something to dismiss.

But the shout that came next was so clear and shocking that it wiped his jumbled thoughts clean in an instant.

“A-all Gates across Eurasia are mutating at once.”

“What?”

“At least twenty percent of them have reached levels high enough to progress into Monster Waves…”

He didn’t hear the rest.

Seized by a sudden ringing in his ears, the superior fell silent. He squeezed out every last bit of strength and managed to say one thing.

“Tell the higher-ups immediately.”

“Which higher-ups, exactly…?”

There was no time to answer.

There were more than a thousand Gates scattered across Europe and Asia.

Shoving aside his hesitant subordinate, the superior picked up a special communications device he hadn’t touched once in the more than ten years since he’d been appointed head of this place.

A direct line to one place and one place only.

After a signal that seemed to ring on forever, someone answered. A tremor crept into the recipient’s voice as they summed up the situation.

“Activate Code Black.”

That was the end of the call.

But both of them knew that this brief conversation, lasting less than a minute, would go down in history.

As would anyone who understood what *Code Black* meant.

And those facing the recipient on-screen—the person who had just set down the receiver, the President of the United States—belonged to the tiny fraction of humanity privy to that top-secret information.

“It’s begun.”

“…Yes. In the end.”

Though they differed in race and gender, these two hundred or so people shared one thing: they all led a nation. For a while, they looked at one another in silence.

There was only one exception among them: a distinctly young East Asian man.

He wasn’t a national leader, nor did he have the seasoned political instincts they did. But he had every right to attend this gathering.

He was also the person who best understood the wishes of someone unable to attend today.

“It’s begun, but it isn’t over.”

His face was still healing, his hair matted with blood.

But no one criticized him for appearing before them like that without showing proper respect.

No—they wouldn’t dare.

The young man before them was a hero who had bled and fought for the world in their place.

Just as his grandfather, recorded in humanity’s history, had—and just as those who had fallen in Moscow today had.

Standing alone, as if his place here belonged to someone else, Choi Minwoo continued, his eyes and voice burning like torches.

“We will end this war.”

The ominous code name that hadn’t been spoken anywhere for decades: Code Black.

No—the Great Cataclysm.

The irreversible war had already begun, and the hero was not dead yet.

Chapter 1173

Humans are creatures that learn.

Of course, they sometimes forget important things. But if they forgot everything without ever learning a thing, humanity as we know it wouldn't exist.

They kept learning, little by little.

Over millions of years, they never stopped advancing.

They learned to use fire and shape stone, until at last they glimpsed the boundless void above the clouds.

But for humanity, which had built a great civilization over such an unfathomable stretch of time, thirty-odd years were far too short to forget the horrific catastrophe known as the Great Cataclysm.

Wheeeeeee!

A blaring siren swept over the city—no, over the entire world.

It spread faster than the magical power rising from the frozen lands of the Far East could stain the sky, with an urgency beyond comparison.

Naturally, every available person and resource was thrown into action without restraint.

Governments declared martial law and deployed the military to evacuate their citizens to safe zones. The whole process moved swiftly and efficiently.

For better or worse, the fear that had gripped people since Morgoth's appearance meant they had either evacuated already or were ready to leave at a moment's notice.

But even those still beneath the blue sky faced no less danger.

—Monster Wave detected 3.2 kilometers[3931] away to the east and west!

—Sending location and scale. Deploy immediately!

The System was right again.

The rift stage was over. The Collapse had begun.

As magical power spiraled out of control, countless Gates scattered around the world opened their dark maws, one after another. Monsters poured out of that cursed world, rampaging with greater strength and savagery.

Just like now.

Rumble, rumble.

The ground trembled at vibrations coming from far away.

So did the hand gripping the handle of a Tower Shield bigger than its owner, tight enough to crush it.

Thump.

[3931] 3.2 kilometers is about 2 miles.

At the heavy touch that suddenly landed on his shoulder, the young man jumped as if burned. Then he let out a sigh of relief.

"…Team Leader."

"You're jumpy, kid."

The middle-aged man grinned, showing his teeth through his bristly beard. The young man might have been annoyed, but he swallowed hard and answered.

"N-no, I'm not."

"Sure you are. I can tell. Just be honest."

"Well… a little."

"Look at this guy. You call yourself a Hunter, and you're scared before the fight's even started?"

"…I'm sorry."

The young man's face fell. The middle-aged man, who'd only been pretending to look stern, chuckled, and so did the Hunters around them.

"Team Leader, you keep that up and the kid'll cry. Give it a rest."

"Come on. What kind of man cries over this? We've all been through it. Back in my day…"

"Jesus, here comes his 'back in my day' latte again.[3932] And all he ever drinks is Mocha Gold."

"I switched a while ago. White Gold now."

"Good for you."

"Thanks."

"Don't mention it. It's nothing."

Listening to the old guys chatter, the young man felt like his head was about to burst.

Where am I, and who am I?

This was a serious situation. He ought to be on edge. So why was their conversation enough to drain every bit of tension out of him?

Did I pick the wrong team?

Of course, there was a serious flaw in that thought.

He hadn't had a choice in the first place.

The man who'd "picked up" this twenty-year-old and brought him into a veteran party with an average age of 41.5 spoke up.

"How about it?"

"Huh?"

"Feeling a little better?"

[3932]The Korean phrase for "back in my day" sounds like "latte," setting up the instant-coffee joke.

The young man blinked, then answered in a voice much calmer than before, though even more bewildered.

“Uh, yes.”

“You were so stiff I figured I’d mess with you a little. Don’t be too hard on me for fooling around at my age.”

“N-no, not at all. I’d never think that.”

“Well, I’d understand if you did. Everyone’s nervous at first. You can’t help being on edge.”

The middle-aged man patted the young man’s shoulder encouragingly and laughed out loud.

It was such a warm laugh that it was hard to believe it came from a man whose face could make even a hardened criminal back down.

Maybe that was why the young man, who hardly dared open his mouth in this veteran party, worked up the courage to speak.

“Um, could I ask you something?”

Thankfully, that laugh hadn’t come from a vicious criminal pretending to be an ordinary person.

The middle-aged man readily nodded, and the young man cautiously continued.

“Why did you choose me…?”

His words trailed off after only a few syllables.

But that was enough. The middle-aged man answered without a moment’s hesitation.

“You reminded me of someone.”

“Reminded you of someone…?”

“Yeah. Someone I know.”

Truth be told, when the middle-aged man first saw the young man two days ago, he’d looked like every other rookie he’d ever seen.

Arms and legs locked stiff. Lips parched. Eyes darting around anxiously.

But if that had been all there was to him, the middle-aged man wouldn’t have chosen him as a teammate to entrust with his life.

“I saw you training.”

“Training?”

“Yeah. You were working hard. Hard enough to look desperate.”

“But that was…”

“I know. All the rookies there were doing it. Trying to stand out so they’d get into a decent team.”

That was true.

Two days ago, when they'd first met, hundreds of rookies fresh out of the regional Hunter Training Center had gathered there, showing what they could do while they waited for their team assignments.

They wanted a team with a better chance of survival.

Not to earn more money like before, but to protect the one thing they couldn't trade for anything: their lives.

And of all those rookies, the young man had been the only one who wasn't there.

"Where were you then?"

"Outside. I needed to find somewhere without people, somewhere with a bit of space."

"Why?"

"Because I had to train."

"You could've trained in there like everyone else and shown them what you could do, couldn't you? Even ordinary people know the staff watch the waiting room from the monitor room."

"That's true, but…"

The young man hesitated, then continued.

"I didn't think I could train properly in there."

Of course he couldn't. It was a waiting room, not the training room used for official tests. Spacious as it was, anyone would have trouble concentrating with that many people swinging bladed weapons around.

But the young man was different.

He might have been doing the same thing as the others, but his reason for doing it was entirely different.

He was giving the training everything he had.

Not to get onto a good team, but to become even a little stronger.

That day, the middle-aged man had secretly followed him to an empty lot.
Watching him train there alone brought back a memory from a few years ago.

"That guy was like that, too."

"Who?"

"The friend I mentioned earlier. I met him at a Hunter manpower office. He was young, like you—no, he was just a kid. A rookie at a glance. I figured I wouldn't be seeing him for long."

"Was there a reason you thought that?"

"He was F-rank."

"Ah."

F-rank.

That one word was enough for the young man to understand.

An untouchable in the Hunter world.

So far beneath the bottom that you could tack UCK onto the F and it would fit perfectly.

Even the young man, on the day of his first rank assessment, had looked at the E glowing on the monitor and thought:

At least I'm not F-rank.

But just as the young man was different, so was the "guy" the middle-aged man was talking about.

"At first, I had no idea I'd keep seeing him for over half a year."

"At least he managed to find work, then."

"What are you talking about? I said he was F-rank. I had some experience and connections, so there were places that'd occasionally call me in as a porter. But an F-rank rookie? Not a chance."

"But you just said…"

"I said I saw him. I didn't say we worked together."

The young man's eyes widened.

"So he just kept showing up at the manpower office? Even when there was no work?"

"Yeah. For nearly half a year. From the crack of dawn until evening, without missing a single day."

Most people would have quit by then.

If they were ordinary people, that is.

"He didn't. He'd leave a perfectly good sofa behind, climb the hill behind the office, and train like hell every day. Like some guy I saw two days ago."

"…!"

"He'd take a number, train, come back when his turn was up, get turned down like always, take another number, train again… He never even got near a Gate, but by closing time he'd be more exhausted than someone who'd done five runs in a day."

The young man listened, dazed, then answered honestly.

"I think I would've lost it halfway through."

"Right? And here's the funny part: he always looked miserable and kept mouthing *fuck, fuck*, but he trained harder than anyone I'd ever seen. He didn't do it because he found it easy. He did it even though it was hard. Every single day."

"That's incredible."

"Yeah. He's an incredible guy."

"No, I mean you, too, Team Leader."

"Me?"

"If you saw him every day for half a year, doesn't that mean you were doing the same thing?"

The middle-aged man was quiet for a moment, then let out a hearty laugh.

"You got me. Heh. But I'll never be like that guy."

"I don't think that's true. You're already amazing."

It wasn't flattery.

Just as the middle-aged man had watched him, the young man had been watching his superior closely, too.

Two days was hardly any time at all, but it had been more than enough to see that the man deserved his respect.

"My dream is to become like you, Team Leader."

"…Me?"

"Yes. You have character, skill, and you work hard. I even saw a news article about you once. I remember the headline: *From F-rank to B-rank: One Hunter's Extraordinary Ups and Downs.*"

The young man had dredged up an embarrassing chapter of his life that the middle-aged man would rather forget. Laughter broke out around them, and the middle-aged man scratched his bushy beard, his face turning red.

He was just about to stammer out a reply when his expression hardened.

Rrrrrumble.

The vibrations were stronger than they'd been ten minutes ago. Now they weren't just coming up through the soles of their feet; they were shaking their whole bodies.

It's coming.

Everyone felt it at once, and realized anew how close they stood to death.

But they couldn't back down.

They were humanity's last line of defense.

They must have been given their powers for this very moment.

"Hey, rookie."

"Yes, Team Leader."

The young man answered hoarsely when the call came from behind him.

At some point, his hand and his Tower Shield had stopped shaking.

"Thanks."

"What?"

"For saying I'm someone's dream. Thanks."

Still smiling, the middle-aged man—Im Kkeokjeong, Team Leader of Ares Guild's Team 32—pulled his helmet down low.

I may not be able to become like that guy, but I'm a Hunter, too.

He fixed his gaze on the dust cloud rising a few hundred meters[3933] away and shouted with all his might.

[3933] A few hundred meters is roughly several hundred yards.

“Formation—!”

At that moment, as a roar pierced the sky, the communicator on Im Kkeokjeong’s chest received a message.

—Attention, all Hunters. Alpha—Alpha has awakened.

A blade-sharp wind swept across the battlefield.

Chapter 1174

The first thought I had when I opened my eyes was simple.

Is this a dream?

It wasn't an unreasonable thought.

Anyone who saw that spotless white ceiling, dozens of meters[3934] overhead in a room the size of a sports field, would probably have thought the same.

But a moment later, I realized it was real.

This place…

I recognized it.

Or rather, maybe not familiar exactly, but I'd definitely been here before.

I vividly remembered staying in a similar place, both in that dreamlike realm of my thoughts and in reality.

Then a voice confirmed it.

"You were sleeping soundly."

His voice carried unmistakable exhaustion.

I turned toward it, saw a familiar face, and parted my dry lips.

"Yeah. I do tend to sleep a lot."

I saw a faint smile appear on Team Leader Choi's usually stern face.

From the way he looked at me, I was probably smiling, too.

For Hunters, meeting again alive meant something special.

But the smile that briefly touched Choi Minwoo's lips, and the joy of seeing each other again, lasted only a moment.

They were alive, as they'd just said. Which meant they had to face reality.

"How long has it been?"

Jin Taekyung didn't beat around the bush, and Choi Minwoo saw no reason to hide the truth.

"Three days. About seventy-six hours, to be exact."

"…Three days."

It wasn't a long time.

For someone living an ordinary life, it was just the blink of an eye.

But Jin Taekyung knew better.

He'd known from the moment he saw Choi Minwoo, exhausted from head to toe.

No—maybe he'd known even before he lost consciousness.

[3934] One meter is about 3.28 ft.

“A lot happened while you were away, Mr. Jin.”

Choi Minwoo paused to catch his breath, then added, almost to himself,

“A lot. So much.”

For a while, only Choi Minwoo’s voice echoed through the vast, empty white space. When his story ended, the silence that followed lasted even longer.

Unlike Jin Taekyung’s mind, where countless scenes and voices were still swirling together.

Let me ask you one thing.

“You have my permission.”

Why?

“If you can grow even a little stronger, what comes next will be all the more entertaining.”

Jin Taekyung remembered the end of the wicked Dragon who had made the world tremble.

He remembered the vivid emotion that even the shadow of death looming right in front of him couldn’t hide.

“Fight with every last bit of strength you have. Keep surpassing yourself. Keep struggling.”

Even as his final breath faded, Morgoth hadn’t shown the slightest anger.

“So I can see it from where I am.”

It had been nothing more than a sigh.

A sigh born of regret: he hadn’t been the one chosen by God, and he wouldn’t get to experience the grand game about to begin.

The vague foreboding Jin Taekyung had felt then had become reality three days later, sweeping across the world.

He knew what was going to happen.

Judging by Morgoth’s actions, Jin Taekyung didn’t think he’d wanted this outcome from the start.

But that no longer mattered.

The Dragon Heart—Pandora’s box, filled with every kind of calamity—had opened.

Not in myth, but in reality.

The power contained in the wicked Dragon’s heart, which had pulsed for thousands of years, was incomparably greater than that of the Hatchling Michael Silbert had defeated in Paris.

It was without precedent.

Even if Choi Minwoo hadn’t told him what had happened, Jin Taekyung’s own senses would have proved it.

Beep-beep-beep.

SYSTEM

—There are System messages you haven't checked.
—The distribution and density of magical power are skyrocketing...
—Current progress of the rift...

Jin Taekyung wasn't the only one who'd woken up after three days.

Dozens of holographic windows he hadn't been able to check while unconscious flooded his vision like a wave, sweeping him along with them.

Among them, his eyes caught on words glowing an especially vivid red, like reefs hidden beneath a violent current.

SYSTEM

—Quest success requirements have not been met.
—Main Quest, Rift and Collapse, has failed.
—A new Main Quest, The Foreordained Collapse, has been created.
—Would you like to view this Quest? Y / N

Jin Taekyung thought that final message, asking for his consent, was crueler than ever.

He had no other choice.

...View Quest.

And a little while later, Jin Taekyung finally broke the long silence.

"Team Leader Choi."

"Yes?"

"I need you to gather everyone. Right now."

Choi Minwoo already had a good idea who Jin Taekyung meant by "everyone."

He knew the request included one being who was more human than most humans, too.

Maybe it was because the space was so vast, but Team Leader Choi's absence—he'd left without asking a single question—felt like a big one.

Still, I wasn't lonely.

I had someone to talk to.

Granted, there was the slight problem that he was in no condition to hold a conversation.

Knock, knock.

I tapped on the transparent recovery capsule as if it were a door, then gazed at the face of the man sleeping deeply inside.

Cheon Taemin.

I'd learned as soon as I regained consciousness that this was a secret space deep beneath the Pentagon.

A vast hospital room and shelter built for one person alone, inaccessible even to the President of the United States.

"Well, now there are two of us."

My muttered words received no answer.

As always.

I kept talking anyway.

"I know what kind of person you are. Better than anyone else in the world."

There was no longer any doubt that Cheon Taemin and the Martial God were the same person.

Or that he'd been a Player who'd used the System before I did.

But one question remained deep in my heart.

"How are you… still alive?"

It was a cruel thing to ask someone who was still breathing, but I had to ask.

The instruction manual for that beat-up old capsule, where all of this had begun, said the capsule remained permanently bound to its Player until the Player died.

Ironically, that incomprehensible error was what had given me the reckless courage to face Morgoth alone.

I thought that if I died, you might wake up.

I swallowed the words before they could leave my throat.

At the same time, I remembered something Morgoth had said.

The one chosen by God.

I didn't doubt it anymore.

I had been chosen.

Whether I'd wanted it or not.

Some great being existed—a being humanity had never encountered, even after reaching beyond the clouds and into space. Another dimension existed, too.

And that unknown being was asking me a question.

Through the receiver called the System.

Open System window. View Quest.

Ding!

SYSTEM

Quest
The Foreordained Collapse
At long last, the balance of the world has crumbled.
This is no mere coincidence.
It is the spark left behind by an invader from beyond this world, and the flame kindled by all of humanity, yourself included.
But one last chance remains.
Stave off the collapse, however little you can, and save the world.
At the same time, remember this:
Just as a mountain leaves its mark when it moves, every choice you make will affect the whole world.
Grade: None
Restriction: Jin Taekyung
Mission: ???
Reward: ???
Failure: ???
—This Quest may change drastically depending on the Player's choices.
—Be as cautious as you can. A single choice may bring about irreversible consequences.

This was a first.

No Quest had ever warned me in words or a tone so grave.

The decision I'd already made began to waver.

Maybe—maybe my choice really would bring about the terrible consequences the System had warned me about.

But there was no time.

I couldn't shake the feeling that if I delayed any longer, things would truly become irreversible. It weighed on my body and mind as surely as the hurried footsteps I could sense beyond the countless layers of magic covering this place.

Whoosh.

The spells came undone under the Grand Mage's hand, revealing familiar faces.

Comrades I could trust with my back. Friends I'd gladly give my life for. People I could call family now.

I turned to them and spoke.

"Have any of you ever traveled between dimensions?"

The Skeleton—or rather, the Undead King—muttered uneasily.

“Uh… are you still half asleep?”

“…You little shit.”

Of course it sounded like a dream.

A nightmare, if anything.

The people—or, more precisely, several people and one monster—couldn’t bring themselves to speak even after I’d finished explaining.

The first to break the unspoken standoff was the huge Grand Mage, who’d looked dazed throughout the whole story.

“I’m serious. If you’d said something like that two or three hundred years ago, they’d have called you a witch and burned you at the stake.”

“I agree, but I’m not a woman.”

“By the time they tied you to the stake, you would’ve been. They’d just have to cut off what’s dangling down there.”

“Fair enough.”

“Actually, we don’t have to go that far back. Before the Great Cataclysm, that story would’ve landed you in a psychiatric hospital.”

“Probably.”

“But now… Yeah. This is after that damn Great Cataclysm. And I’m the Grand Mage.”

That was right.

These were the times we lived in.

It had only been three days since we’d fought to take down a Dragon the size of an aircraft carrier. After hearing my whole story, no one suggested putting me in a psychiatric hospital.

Not even the monster.

None of them doubted a word I’d said.

Even if the world were a little different, I was sure they would have believed me.

Just as Jeok Cheongang had believed in me.

And I’d had only one reason to reveal the secret I’d kept deep in my heart.

“I’m… going to leave. To put an end to all of this.”

I knew where the invader from beyond this world was.

Chapter 1175

Every story has an ending.

Jin Taekyung already knew what it would take to end this nightmarish catastrophe. He had to defeat one being.

“Demon King Asmodeus.”

The name was a curse to modern humanity. As it left his lips, the air around them seemed to freeze.

The old heroes, who still remembered that horrific past vividly after all these decades, looked especially stricken.

“…Asmodeus?”

“That—that can’t be.”

Chuck Hagel and Magic Johnson spoke almost at the same time. Their reactions were exactly what Jin Taekyung had expected.

He’d shared his deepest secrets with them, but they couldn’t take it all in so quickly.

No, this was closer to an instinctive defense: the human urge to deny reality rather than live through that nightmare again.

“I understand. I thought the same thing for a long time.”

Jin Taekyung meant every word.

He hadn’t experienced the Great Cataclysm firsthand, but he’d been born on its final day.

Growing up, he’d been taught about it until he was sick of hearing it: what had happened during the Great Cataclysm, and how humanity had survived.

And how the ruler of the Demon Realm who had caused the Great Cataclysm met his end at the hands of a great hero born of humanity, without leaving so much as a trace.

But…

“He’s alive. I’m certain of it. In another world, under the name Lord of Heaven.”

Just as Cheon Taemin had existed as the Martial God, the king of demons had gained a new name in another world.

The beginning and the end of all this.

Jin Taekyung was certain. To reach the end of the path he’d walked—and the path still ahead of him—he had to reach that bastard.

But no one else could see the shape of the enormous puzzle he’d pieced together while traveling between two worlds. They could only trust the young man standing before them.

And someone did.

“I see. Understood.”

Choi Minwoo's voice was calm. That made it sound all the more unnatural.

As Cheon Taemin's only direct blood relative, Choi Minwoo had more reason than anyone there to be shaken by what he'd heard.

His gaze passed briefly over the others, then settled on Jin Taekyung. It didn't waver in the slightest.

"If that's what you believe, Mr. Jin, that's enough for us."

This time, silence didn't fall.

Choi Minwoo's words had made everything clear.

They trusted Jin Taekyung.

The simple certainty in those words swept away even the faint doubts and denials everyone had kept hidden in their hearts.

Even when everything around you is dark, you can still see the torch moving ahead.

And to them—no, to all humanity—Jin Taekyung was the one torch burning brighter than any other.

"Right. I had it wrong for a moment."

Magic Johnson muttered to himself, then let out a small laugh.

"Still, I never thought my greatest wish would be answered like this."

"Your wish?"

"I couldn't make sense of anything about you, Jin. I wanted to talk you into letting me run all kinds of experiments on you. Maybe even a little dissection, if you agreed…"

Jin Taekyung asked in all sincerity, "Are you insane?"

"Don't worry. I'm not planning to do that anymore. Good grief, you said it was a System? My poor imagination never got that far."

"I don't think anyone would've imagined that."

Song Song, sitting alone among the mountain-sized men, gestured with her eyes toward the seat beside her.

"Look at Uncle Kkeokjeong. He's practically out of his mind."

Every eye turned to Im Kkeokjeong. Still looking dazed, he jumped as though he'd just woken up.

"Huh? Wh-what? Why me? I'm fine."

"You don't look fine."

"No, I was just… listening."

Im Kkeokjeong scratched the back of his head as he struggled to get the words out.

"Honestly, I'm not sure I should even be hearing something this incredible."

"Yeah, I feel the same. Team Leader Choi here—no, our Guild Master—has every right to hear it. But us? Well…"

Jin Taekyung gave a quiet laugh at their reactions.

"What's this about having a right? I called you because you belong here."

And they did.

They might not have known one another for a large part of their lives, but they were friends and comrades who'd been together through some of the hardest, most turbulent times.

There were others he wanted to call but couldn't.

People like Butler Kim, who had passed away, or Faye Chen.

Or his family, who couldn't accept a situation like this, and Seong Jinho, his closest friend since his days at the goshiwon.[3935]

"Oh, that's kind of touching. Didn't know you could say things like that."

"I'm pretty good at it, if I do say so myself."

"Then what were you thinking when we first met? Remember that night we were drinking, and you started going on about Taurus and—"

"…I was wrong."

Starting with that shameful memory, words came pouring in from every direction.

Some were about little things they could barely remember. Others were as vivid as if they'd happened yesterday.

For a while, they laughed and talked together.

None of them said it aloud, but they all felt it.

This might be the last time they faced one another with smiles like these.

Maybe that was why Jin Taekyung couldn't bring himself to speak when the time came to say goodbye.

Tick. Tick.

At some point, the sound of a second hand reached him through his keen senses. Jin Taekyung closed his eyes.

The broken pocket watch.

It was moving—the thing that likely linked the modern world and Murim through the absolute power of time.

I have to leave. Before it's too late.

He knew it in his head and in his heart.

Even so, he felt more conflicted than ever.

Before him were faces he was always glad to see. The faces of precious people he hadn't been able to see hovered before his eyes like mist.

If only this moment could last forever.

But it couldn't.

Time would keep moving. So would the enemy waiting for him in another world.

[3935] A *goshiwon* is a Korean residence of small, inexpensive rented rooms, traditionally used by people studying for exams.

Unless someone stopped him, he always would.

That's why I have to go.

It was the one thing he had to do.

The one thing only he could do.

Jin Taekyung reminded himself of that unchanging truth and opened his eyes. Everyone was looking at him.

As though they'd instinctively sensed that it was time to part.

"Go on, human. Don't make a whole thing out of it."

The Undead King made it sound as though Jin were just popping over to the neighbor's house. Jin Taekyung couldn't help laughing.

He looked at the smiling faces before him. Then, thinking of those who must be desperately searching for him somewhere, he said goodbye.

"I'll come back. I promise."

Muttering the words like a vow to himself, Jin Taekyung logged in.

Deep in the darkness, a being suddenly awoke and drew a deep breath.

Like a child opening its eyes for the first time in a new world.

Or a pitiful evil spirit struggling to feel that it was still alive.

But this time was different.

The air around him. The qi. All of it.

His breath, always ragged and labored, like that of someone on the verge of death, was calm. And a strength and vitality he hadn't felt in decades welled up in his body, which had been as good as dead.

Slowly, but without stopping.

The loyal servant who had been waiting alone for her master in the darkness and silence could sense the change, too.

"Congratulations, great Lord of Heaven."

The Grand Sorceress's voice trembled. She had always been so composed.

Moments earlier, she had recognized the source of a sudden feeling of déjà vu. She'd come here without hesitation to wait for her master.

"This lowly servant dared to wait for her master without permission. Please punish me."

The next moment, an answer rang out—one she'd thought she would never hear.

It came not as a sound, but from deep within the Grand Sorceress's mind.

—You are forgiven.

It could scarcely be called a voice. It was cold as ice, yet the Grand Sorceress trembled with joy.

She’d been right.

The strange sensation she’d felt a moment ago was real. After only a few days, her master had awoken again, having regained even greater power.

And all of this could mean only one thing.

“Has it finally been completed?”

—Far from it.

“Ah…!”

The Grand Sorceress let out a regretful groan before she could stop herself. Then another reverberation filled her mind, and she caught her breath.

—But it will be completed.

“Then…”

—Nothing can stop what has already begun. No one.

“…!”

At that pronouncement, like an oracle, the Grand Sorceress—prostrated with all five limbs on the ground, unable to dare face her master—bowed even lower.

Cold seeped up from the damp stone floor, but she didn’t care. The fierce emotion rising deep within her warmed her body like a ball of fire.

“Please give your command. What should this lowly servant do?”

Her joy was plain in the question. Her master answered in a voice that none could hear.

Not the eternal snows of the Tianshan Mountains. Not the sky touching their peaks, nor the moon and stars beyond.

Nor the countless armies crossing the vast continent, finally nearing the Land of Ruin beyond the desert, could hear the voice.

Chapter 1176

Login—or Logout.

Like the games I played as a kid, crossing an invisible boundary between two worlds had become familiar to me.

The moment everything around me vanished and my vision went dark, I found myself alone.

In darkness so deep I couldn't see an inch ahead.

Of course, it never lasted long.

An unknown force would soon take hold of my consciousness and lead it somewhere. At the end of that journey, the light of a new world would be waiting.

But why?

Something's different.

I sensed it instinctively. What startled me was that even after the thought crossed my mind, the darkness remained.

Why?

The process, the sensations—both had become as familiar as breathing. Now they felt strange.

By now, my consciousness should have crossed from the modern world into Murim. Then I would regain my usual senses and awareness in the other body I'd been apart from. That was the routine.

But this time, everything was different.

The darkness and silence went on for what felt like an eternity.

Then, at the end of that suffocating wait, came the pull.

Whoooosh.

As if caught in a massive tornado, my consciousness was sucked toward depths I couldn't begin to fathom.

I clung with all my strength to the thread of my consciousness as a pull more powerful than anything I'd ever felt threatened to shake it loose.

Damn it. What the hell is this?

If my previous trips had been rides in a limousine, this one was a locomotive.

A broken-down runaway locomotive hurtling down rusted, misaligned tracks, with no engineer to control its speed.

Stop!

The cry rang out in my mind before I could help it.

But a school bully rotten to the core wouldn't stop tormenting someone at a single shout. Neither did the powerful wave carrying my consciousness toward who knew where.

And at the end of that insane ride—

Whooosh!

Darkness split apart as though torn open. A shaft of light brighter than any I'd seen before burst through and swallowed my vision.

With it came a voice, carried to me through senses that had snapped sharply into focus.

"You've come back."

He hadn't asked if I was awake.

He'd asked if I'd come back.

Leaving the frantic ordeal behind me, I slowly opened my eyes and looked at the owner of the voice.

Bells were ringing one after another, beginning with a System message announcing that Login had succeeded. But his voice fell on my ears like spring rain.

"Yes, Master."

Master.

At the ease with which the title came from my lips, the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, widened his eyes.

Then they curved gently, like a full moon.

"Yes. Good to have you back."

At long last, I was in Murim.

The joy of our reunion was brief.

More precisely, there was no need to draw it out.

People who knew each other better than anyone else didn't need many words. Jeok Cheongang and I had been like that for a long time.

And for that very reason, he must have noticed right away that something was wrong with me.

"So, what kind of dogshit situation has happened this time?"

"Are you psychic? How'd you know?"

"Look at yourself. How could I not?"

"What about me? I—oh."

Only then did I realize I was drenched in cold sweat.

It had soaked through my clothes and even the bedding beneath me. So much for having reached the realm of Unaffected by Cold and Heat a long time ago.

"When did this start?"

"A little while ago. You were groaning so much I thought you might shit yourself."

"…"

Where had that warm feeling from a moment ago gone? Was it just me, or did the air smell like a public restroom now?

I grimaced and answered, "Hard to say. More than one thing comes to mind. Anyway, where's everyone else?"

That was what I'd wanted to ask first.

No matter how I looked around, Jeok Cheongang was the only face I could see. And aside from the snorting of the horses pulling us along, I couldn't sense anyone nearby.

His answer made my already-prickling nerves go cold.

"Gone."

"…!"

My heart dropped with a thud. That was exactly how it felt.

"Gone?" I asked, my voice trembling.

"I said they're gone."

"So they were here, but—"

"Ah, they're gone! Right now!"

Jeok Cheongang snapped, then continued.

"To be precise, they all left about one shichen[3936] ago. They needed to scout the area and find a place to camp tonight. They'll probably be back soon."

What the hell?

I stared at him in silence. My heart had long since returned to its proper place.

"You should've said that first."

"Look at this disrespectful brat. You're the one who didn't listen to the end. How's that my fault?"

As Jeok Cheongang glared at me, I turned my head slightly to the side.

Outside the large, beautiful eight-horse carriage the emperor of the Great Nation—no, the Great Ming Empire—had bestowed on me alone, darkness covered the world.

"By the way, where are we…?"

"Xinjiang."

Xinjiang.

The vastest land under heaven, and a Land of Ruin no one had dared invade for ages.

While I'd been away from Murim, the journey that began in Qinghai had finally brought us here.

[3936] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

Even now, grains of sand trickled through the gaps in the carriage, proof that we were deep in the heart of Xinjiang.

"The Taklamakan Desert."

Jeok Cheongang muttered the name, then spat out the sand that had gotten into his mouth.

"Damn desert. When I think of all the hell I've been through for nearly a month, I really…"

I didn't hear the rest.

Not because he'd trailed off, or because of the fierce sandstorm beating against the carriage window.

A month. A whole month has already passed?

I'd spent less than a week in the modern world.

Yet a month had passed in Murim during those few days.

The axis of time has gone out of alignment. Beyond the point of no return.

I'd already suspected as much.

When I returned to the modern world after fighting the Blood Lord in Qinghai, I'd realized the time ratio was badly off.

But foreboding was one thing when it stayed in my head. Seeing it become reality was another.

Tick. Tick.

The cold ticking of the [Broken Pocket Watch] I'd tucked deep in my Inventory just before logging in seemed to ring in my ears like a phantom sound.

But… maybe it's a good thing this much time has passed. It means we're that much closer to our destination.

A month was no short stretch of time.

Especially given the situation the world faced now.

But unlike the modern world, which had suffered terrible damage in just ten days since Morgoth's arrival, there hadn't been any significant damage here yet.

Or at least, that was how it felt at the moment.

Whether I'd still think so after asking my next question was another matter.

"While I was asleep, did anything…?"

"You mean, did anything happen? No. Nothing out of the ordinary."

Jeok Cheongang answered without hesitation, as if he'd known what I was going to ask. His voice dropped as he added, "It's so peaceful it feels strange."

"What do you mean?"

"Just what I said. The sky is murky and impossible to predict. One moment it's snow or rain, the next it's heat that could melt you, or even hail. But aside from that, there's nothing."

That wasn't particularly surprising.

The sudden climate changes were happening in both the modern world and Murim, and they were nothing new by now.

Besides, this was Xinjiang, where the Lord of Heaven had holed up. If anything, the changes here would be worse, not better.

What caught my attention was the last thing Jeok Cheongang had said.

"Nothing at all?"

"That's right. None of us thought much of it on the first day. But it didn't take long for everyone, this old man included, to notice."

And when Jeok Cheongang went on to explain, I realized there wasn't the slightest exaggeration or lie in what he'd said.

"At first, nobody paid it any mind. We were busy taking turns scouting the area every half shichen[3937] and standing watch through the night."

That was only natural.

This was Xinjiang.

The thousand-year Sacred Land of the Hundred Thousand Demonic Disciples, who'd once swept across the land, and the base of Dark Heaven.

Dark Heaven had unleashed bloodshed across the Central Plains. It wouldn't have been surprising if they'd turned Xinjiang, practically their own front yard, into a sea of blood.

"But strangely, it was quiet. None of those crazy fanatics who'd swarmed us like a pack of dogs in Qinghai. None of those monsters that defied all reason. Not even a band of common mounted bandits. At first, I thought maybe the bastards were scared."

It wasn't arrogance or carelessness that had led him to think so.

Just before we set out from Qinghai, the emperor and the leaders of the alliance army—the foremost figures of Murim—had divided a force of well over a hundred thousand into three groups. We were one of them.

Our group numbered fewer than twenty. But look at who was in it.

Two Stars and the strongest of the Ten Kings.

The Bow Saint, the Slaughter Saint, and the Fire King, who stood shoulder to shoulder with them.

Even with me unconscious, those three alone were more than enough to be called an army.

"But the very next day, I realized I'd been wrong from the start."

Jeok Cheongang muttered in a low voice, then suddenly jerked his chin toward the window.

"Do you see?"

[3937] A *shichen* is a traditional Chinese time unit of approximately two hours; half a shichen is approximately one hour.

“What are you—”

I frowned at the gesture, then stopped mid-sentence.

In that instant, I understood.

Beyond the window, the vast desert stretched into the darkness, filled with nothing but sand.

At the same time, not a sound could be heard.

“Could it be…?”

“That’s right.”

Jeok Cheongang continued, his voice heavy and subdued.

“There isn’t a single living thing in this land.”

Chapter 1177

A land of death.

Just as the name said, a place utterly devoid of life.

The truth I'd failed to notice came over me with the chill of a blade pressed to the back of my neck.

No living things at all? How is that possible?

I swallowed the question almost as soon as it sprang to mind.

It was a foolish question.

If the Lord of Heaven—no, the Demon King Asmodeus—stood at the beginning and end of all this, then it was even less surprising.

He'd dragged an apocalypse that had existed only in people's imaginations into reality. From the moment I learned what he was, *common sense* had lost all meaning.

Another question quickly took the first one's place. One that was more practical, and closer to the heart of the matter.

I stared out the window. Not a bird called. Not an insect chirped.

"What's the purpose?"

It was far too late to ask *how*.

What mattered to me now—to us—was why.

And it seemed the person hiding in the sandstorm that had blown in from far away, whose presence had settled on the carriage roof a moment earlier, knew that too.

"One of two things."

The Slaughter Saint's voice was boyishly young, yet carried a bleakness that spoke of all the years he'd lived.

"The first is a final battle. Gathering everything in Xinjiang for one last fight."

"Then the second is…"

"I don't know exactly what happened, but the whole of Xinjiang has lost the breath of life. People and animals have legs; they could have gone elsewhere. But even the plants across the region have withered. Dark Heaven's probably behind it."

Jeok Cheongang cut in gruffly.

"Eavesdropping like a rat, only to tell us something that goes without saying."

"Watch your mouth. That rat might cut your throat tonight."

"I wouldn't mind. We're running low on food. Roast rat, nice and crisp, would make a fine breakfast tomorrow."

"That mouth of yours never gets any better. What the hell have you done with all the years you've lived?"

With that curt reply, a shadow fell across the window.

Like a ghost with no substance, the Slaughter Saint passed through the window as if it weren't there and entered the carriage. He stared at me as though he could see straight through whatever I was hiding.

"Anyway, you slept a long time."

I smacked my lips.

I'd been traveling with the Slaughter Saint for quite a while, but this was the first time I'd been gone for a whole month. And by any ordinary measure, no one could sleep for an entire month.

But what could I do? The day would come when I told him the truth myself. For now, I'd have to bluff with a straight face.

"Yeah, I sleep a lot."

"Even so, it's impossible to stay asleep for a month."

"I've got an unusual constitution."

"I've wandered the land for fifty years and seen all kinds of patients. No such constitution exists."

"Congratulations. After fifty years, you've discovered a new one."

"…"

"…"

A suffocating silence filled the carriage. The Slaughter Saint and even Jeok Cheongang stared at me as if I were a madman.

Fair enough. You didn't need medical training to know that was nonsense.

"I'm kidding. I did wake up a few times in between. You know, to take care of basic bodily functions and all that."

"I didn't know that."

"Of course not. Only Master knew. Right?"

Jeok Cheongang blinked at my sudden plea for help, then scratched the back of his head.

"Uh. Well, that is…"

His reaction was a little odd, but the most important thing when lying was to sound natural. I kept talking before the Slaughter Saint could notice.

"I woke up once a few days ago, too. After sleeping so long, I had to pee, and I was hungry."

"When exactly was that?"

"Um… I wasn't fully awake, so I don't really know."

"I see."

The Slaughter Saint nodded as if he understood, then muttered to himself.

"Strange. You woke up several times, and nobody noticed."

"Yeah. Strange, isn't it?"

"Something even stranger happened. Would you like to hear it?"

Was it just my imagination, or had the air gone a little stale?

Uneasy for some reason, I shook my head.

"…No. Not really."

"Surely you're curious."

"I'm fine. Sometimes it's better not to know."

"A good saying. But another one fits this situation better."

The Slaughter Saint's voice was gentler than usual, which made it all the more ominous.

"That mouth of yours is asking for a beating."

"…"

"What do you think?"

What was I supposed to think?

I forced a smile.

"Now I'm very curious. I'd love to hear what happened."

"Taken on its own, it's nothing remarkable. From where I stood, it was mostly a nuisance."

"What do you mean…?"

"What a close Master and Disciple you are. From the first day of our journey, a certain ill-tempered old man raised hell unless I checked on you morning and evening. Not a single day went by in peace."

The Slaughter Saint's eyes sank as he glared at Jeok Cheongang, as though just remembering it exhausted him.

"Lately, his fits reached new heights. You'd been asleep for nearly a month, so he decided something must be wrong. He shouted at me, demanding to know why I couldn't find the problem."

"…"

"That was only two days ago. Anything to say?"

You've got to be kidding me.

Of course I had nothing.

I knew something had felt off. Now I understood Jeok Cheongang's strange reaction earlier.

Under the Slaughter Saint's stare—and mine—Jeok Cheongang looked out the window and muttered, "Well, I didn't shout *that* much…"

"You even called me a quack."

"I didn't put it quite that directly…"

"True. You were a little more roundabout. You asked if I'd learned medicine at a gambling den."

“I did say that, but it wasn’t so harsh…”

“And what possessed you to accuse me of trying to live up to my title as the Slaughter Saint by killing your Disciple?”

“Hmm. I suppose I went too far there. My pride won’t let me apologize, so I’ll offer my regrets instead.”

The answer was steeped in the essence of the Fire Gate Clan—a clan that had been making Murim’s people furious on a regular basis for more than three hundred years. A sound almost escaped me.

Then I saw the Slaughter Saint’s expression and held it in with everything I had.

“You fucking—!”

I was very relieved Cheongpung wasn’t here.

If he’d seen this, he would’ve spouted some nonsense like, *Wow! I’ve never seen the greatest assassin of all time swear before!* Then I would’ve had to watch the greatest assassin of all time lose his temper and go on a rampage.

Fortunately, the man with another identity as the Divine Physician knew how to keep to a minimum standard of decency—unlike my dear Master—and, as a former assassin, had a near-supernatural skill for recovering his composure.

“Fine. Yes… It happens. People close to a patient sometimes can’t think clearly. It happens. I understand.”

After muttering as if trying to hypnotize himself, the Slaughter Saint took a steadying breath and turned to me.

Then he asked something I could never have anticipated.

“So, did you take care of things over there?”

“What?”

“Your hometown. The realm of immortals, wasn’t it?”

“…!”

For a moment, the world seemed to stop.

If not for the carriage’s constant rattling, the sand slipping through the window, and Jeok Cheongang’s conspicuously deliberate clearing of his throat, I might have believed it had.

“Ahem. Well, that’s how it happened.”

That happened. That happened. That happened…

His words seemed to echo, though we weren’t in some deep mountain valley. I closed my eyes for a moment, then opened them and looked at Jeok Cheongang.

He was trying very hard to look stern.

I said nothing. I just kept looking at him.

“W-why are you looking at me like that?”

“…”

"Well, I couldn't help it. You'd been out cold for a whole month. I was worried, and the Slaughter Saint kept getting suspicious…"

"…"

"I only explained a little! Just a little! He's a physician. When he asks about a patient, he ought to know *something* about the patient's condition!"

I let out a long sigh at his halting excuses.

"I understand."

"You'd always woken up after a few days at most. This time, I even wondered if you'd been poisoned with some sleeping drug from the demonic, heterodox arts… What did you say?"

"I said I understand. You had your reasons."

Well, what was done was done.

Maybe it was just me, but I'd grown pretty close to the Slaughter Saint. He was one of my most dependable allies, too. He deserved to know my secret.

To be honest, part of me was relieved it was out.

Besides, the decision had been made by my Master. Jeok Cheongang must have had his reasons. If he'd slept for a whole month like a bear hibernating through winter, even I would have started to suspect something.

Anyway…

"How much did you tell him about me?"

"Hmm. Well…"

Why did I suddenly feel a chill?

I'd only asked in case I needed to fill in the details, but Jeok Cheongang hesitated and glanced at me before answering.

"I told them more or less what I knew. Their reactions varied at first, but they all believed me."

"Oh, that's fine. I was planning to tell him soon anyway… Wait. Their reactions varied?"

That was strange.

There was only one of him. How could there be several reactions?

A shout from somewhere in the distance answered my question.

"Waaah! Benefactor! You're back! Did you have a good trip?"

Ah.

Chapter 1178

There’s no such thing as a perfect secret.

Birds hear what’s said by day, rats hear what’s said by night, and sooner or later, it all comes out of someone’s mouth.

“I swear to Heaven, this old man told exactly one person.”

The culprit who’d first let my secret slip made his declaration like a newborn letting out its first cry. At that, the “one person” in question licked his lips.

“Well, I was only going to check a few facts. How was I supposed to believe a word that crazy old man said?”

“And then?” I asked quietly.

“I had no choice but to corner the person who seemed to know you best and ask him.”

The Slaughter Saint’s gaze shifted to Hyuk Mujin. Huddled in a corner of the carriage, Mujin had been watching everyone’s reactions. Now he stammered out an answer.

“To be precise, you kidnapped me in the dead of night while I was sound asleep and buried me in the desert. With only my head sticking out.”

“That’s right. But he turned out to be surprisingly tight-lipped. He insisted he’d rather die than tell me anything that might put you in danger.”

Perhaps buoyed by the Slaughter Saint’s testimony, Hyuk Mujin straightened his hunched shoulders.

“You heard him, right? That’s how loyal I am.”

“So, I had no choice but to tell him a rough version of what I’d heard. Then the very next day, some random weirdo came asking about you.”

Right on cue, that “random fool” poked his head in.

“Benefactor! Benefactor! You really came from the realm of immortals? It’s true? Wow! I’ve never met anyone from the realm of immortals before!”

“Yeah. Just like that.”

The Slaughter Saint gave Cheongpung a tired glare, then added, “Anyway, I only told one person, too.”

Hyuk Mujin drew his shoulders in again and muttered, “So did I.”

Yeah. Of course he had.

But if I were Hyuk Mujin, I wouldn’t have shared a “stupendous secret I couldn’t possibly keep to myself” with Cheongpung.

Why? Simple.

Because he was Cheongpung.

“Benefactor, me too! I only told Young Lady Ju!”

Maybe an innocence-proving contest had started without my noticing.

Cheongpung shouted with tremendous enthusiasm, and Jeok Cheongang nodded.

“He’s not wrong. The problem was that he said it at just about that volume, at a meal where most of us were gathered.”

“…”

This was giving me a headache.

I shook my head and happened to meet someone’s eyes.

Unlike the others, she’d been silent this whole time, without so much as a reaction.

Ju Hwaran.

“Ah, Young Lady Ju.”

I greeted her with an awkward smile, but she didn’t answer.

She only stared at me, her gaze pricking my face like a thin needle.

No, she wasn’t the only one looking at me.

A hush had fallen over the carriage. Everyone was watching.

Well. I didn’t know.

I felt like I should say something, but what? And how?

Should I act like nothing happened? Or apologize for not telling them sooner…?

My thoughts were tangling like a ball of yarn when her tightly closed red lips parted.

“You’re not, are you?”

“Huh? What do you mean, all of a sudden?”

“You’re not actually an immortal or something instead of a human, are you?”

“An immortal?”

I blinked at her. Then I understood and let out a small, disbelieving laugh.

“Come on. Do I look that impressive to you, Young Lady Ju?”

“Don’t laugh.”

“…Sorry. I couldn’t help it. But I’m really not.”

“Are you sure?”

“Of course. What else would I be if not human? A few misunderstandings piled up, and somehow my home came to be called the realm of immortals. But people live there just like they do here.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Calling the two worlds the same would be a huge stretch.

Even setting aside the difference in technology, at least around here you wouldn’t run into a monster on your way to the inn at the intersection near your house.

But I didn’t bother explaining that, and Ju Hwaran didn’t seem inclined to press the point.

Instead, she asked another question I hadn't expected.

"Then how old are you really?"

"…Where did that come from?"

"I'm just curious. You said only your soul goes back and forth, and your world is different from this one."

I answered, still a little bewildered.

"Uh, well. Around twenty-eight?"

"Around?"

"No, that's right. Going back and forth a few times has messed up my sense of time, so I got confused for a second…"

I'd started rambling out excuses without meaning to when Ju Hwaran cut me off in a voice as sharp as a blade.

"So you haven't even turned thirty yet."

"That's right."

"And you're not an immortal or a celestial who's lived for five hundred years since ascending to immortality."

"…I told you, I'm human."

Ascended to immortality? Please.

I'd been called an idiot plenty of times. By Hayeon.

And if I really were a five-hundred-year-old immortal, the one pulling this eight-horse carriage right now would be the Lord of Heaven, not a horse.

Wouldn't that be nice?

I was lost in that sweet, sad thought when Ju Hwaran delivered her verdict like a judge who'd finished hearing the case.

"That settles it, then."

"Huh?"

"It's fine. You're human, and you're around twenty-eight."

It was a strange verdict.

No account of the case. No sentence.

But that was enough.

I didn't know what it was, but it was settled.

No, honestly, I think I do know.

For some reason, my chest felt tight. Somewhere close to my heart.

At the same time, another part of it grew heavy.

Was it okay to feel this way right now? Did I have any right to?

Maybe that was why I found it hard to meet her eyes as she kept looking steadily at me, with everyone else watching us and making the air between us stranger still.

And why, the next moment, I changed the subject for no good reason.

“Anyway, when will the others be back?”

“H-hm?”

“The people who aren’t here.”

Jeok Cheongang, who’d been looking back and forth between Ju Hwaran and me, cleared his throat.

“Ahem. Why do you ask all of a sudden?”

“I want to see them. And now that it’s come to this, there’s something I’d like to tell everyone myself.”

“Well, they’re searching different areas, so they’ll all be back before long. But there’s no need to gather them for that. Some of them still don’t know anything about you.”

“What? But earlier, that human Cheongpung clearly—”

“Yes, that careless mouth of his said it loud enough for everyone to hear. At a meal where *most* of us were gathered.”

“Oh.”

I let out a short exclamation.

At the same time, it wasn’t hard to think of the person most likely not to have heard my secret yet.

“Great Sir.”

The Supreme Peak master we’d first met in Gansu, who’d accompanied us all the way here.

A mysterious eccentric as baffling as his wild, unkempt hair. Even he didn’t know who he was.

“What Great Sir? The fellow loses his mind several times a day.”

Jeok Cheongang snorted, then continued.

“If he’d happened to be there, we couldn’t have helped it. But it still didn’t sit right with this old man to go out of my way to tell him, so I told everyone to keep quiet. He’s been quite useful, but a secret is a secret, and we don’t even know who he is.”

“Hmm.”

“I can guess what you’re thinking. I’m not going to force my judgment on you. Do as you like about that fellow you call Great Sir. But…”

Jeok Cheongang trailed off and scratched his bushy beard.

“There’s someone else I’m more concerned about than him.”

“Someone else?”

“The ones here have more or less understood and accepted it by now. But things don’t always work out so neatly. Old folks especially have trouble understanding anything new.”

Just as I’d thought of Great Sir, I remembered another person who wasn’t here.

Bow Saint.

I muttered the words to myself and looked out the window.

Perhaps because clouds were passing across the pitch-black sky, the stars looked especially dim tonight.

Desert nights were merciless.

By day, the heat seemed ready to burn the whole world. Once the sun set and darkness fell, an icy chill blanketed the land.

Yet even in the cold that seeped to the bone, the slender shadow cast alone atop a sand dune did not waver.

That was only natural. The master who cast it had long since surpassed the realm of Unaffected by Cold and Heat.

But that wasn't the only reason.

"The realm of immortals… The realm of immortals."

Bow Saint gazed into the dark desert, her eyes clouded with thought.

The boundless sea of sand before her seemed to mirror her heart.

No end in sight, no matter how far she walked. Nothing within it but hardship and rough grains of sand.

"So that was the secret you were hiding."

She murmured the words softly.

The desert at night was an excellent listener.

It asked no questions. It only let the wind pass through in silence, from wherever that wind had come.

But it was no good for conversation.

No, even if the desert could speak, that wouldn't change.

The person the Bow Saint wanted to speak to was someone else.

"…Martial God."

Her fingers, hard as steel and callused despite her translucent skin, searched inside her robe.

Through the fabric, they found the old letter the Martial God had left for her alone, containing a secret she therefore could tell no one.

"Is this what you want?"

The Bow Saint could not understand.

She had trusted and followed the letter's instructions only because the Martial God had left it. From the beginning until now, she had never been able to make sense of what it said.

And after hearing Jin Taekyung’s secret just a few days ago, she found it even harder to understand.

“Is this truly… right?”

At that moment—

Rustle.

A faint sound behind her reached the Bow Saint’s ears.

Chapter 1179

Bow Saint reacted at once.

As if she'd expected it, she kicked off the ground and retreated. At the same moment, she thrust a palm wreathed in white Force toward the source of the sound.

Boom!

A blinding flash engulfed the sand dune where she had stood alone.

No, there were two of them now.

An uninvited guest had arrived.

How could I make such a mistake…?

Normally, she could keep track of everything within twenty-odd zhang[3938] without even drawing on her internal energy. Yet she hadn't noticed an enemy approaching until they were within a dozen zhang[3939]. Bow Saint bit her lip.

She'd been too deep in thought. Her heart was more unsettled than ever, and that had surely played a part.

But none of it excused her carelessness. Not here in Xinjiang.

If there were two consolations, the first was that the enemy's stealth technique was worse than she'd expected. The second was…

"Gwaaah!"

With a strangled scream, the enemy flew into the distance and landed with a wet smack. The back of the figure sprawled there looked rather familiar.

More familiar still was the dreadful stench that had come barging in ahead of him like a thief.

…That smell.

As an archer, Bow Saint had eyesight second to none. This time, she hadn't needed it. Her nose had recognized him first.

The stench was so awful she feared smelling it in her dreams. She wondered how she had failed to notice it until now.

Suppressing a wave of nausea, Bow Saint watched the uninvited guest groan and get to his feet.

"Why are you here?"

There was a trace of suspicion in her voice.

Then, as always, he left her dumbfounded.

"Gah! An enemy! It's Dark Heaven!"

"…"

[3938] A zhang is a traditional length of ten chi, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

[3939] A zhang is a traditional length of ten chi, approximately 3.03 meters (9.94 feet).

“Reveal your mask and take off your identity! How dare you ambush this lady! Do you not fear the Lord of Heaven?”

Bow Saint couldn’t hold back any longer. She spoke up, stunned from beginning to end.

“You’ve got it backward.”

“What?”

“You take off a mask, not your identity.”

He wasn’t wearing a mask, either, but she saw no point in explaining that. Even if she went through his mistakes one by one, he’d forget by tomorrow—no, within a shichen.[3940]

That man, who referred to himself as “this lady” without a second thought, was Great Sir.

At least he knows Dark Heaven is the enemy.

Bow Saint sighed inwardly. Just then, Great Sir finally recognized her, and his eyes widened.

“Wait, why are you here, Young Lady?”

“First, I’m not young enough to be called that. Second, that’s my question for you. I already asked it.”

She added quietly, “And I still haven’t heard an answer.”

The Force around her hand had vanished without a trace, but appearances could be deceiving. Several jiazi’s[3941] worth of internal energy continued to circulate within her, faster and more quietly than before, ready to unleash its full power whenever she wished.

One mistake was enough. If she’d made the same mistake twice, she would neither be known as Bow Saint nor have survived the Great Faction War.

“I thought you were supposed to scout somewhere else. Am I mistaken?”

Bow Saint held on to her suspicion.

They called him Great Sir for convenience, but he was an eccentric whose true identity no one knew. Great Sir himself could barely keep his mind straight. How could anyone else know who he was?

He remembered neither his name nor his past. Even when the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, had declared, “This’ll bring back memories from before you were born,” and treated him to a thorough pummeling, nothing had changed.

There was only one thing Bow Saint knew for certain about him: he had inherited the martial arts of an orthodox sect.

His internal energy is undoubtedly pure. But that alone isn’t enough to put me at ease.

[3940] A shichen is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours.

[3941] A jiazi is a traditional sixty-year cycle.

Most of the traitors recruited by Dark Heaven had belonged to orthodox factions. The Murong Family, one of the Five Great Families, had been rotten from its roots. What mattered wasn't the martial art but the heart of the person who practiced it.

Besides, Great Sir is a Supreme Peak master. I came across information about him while I was staying at the Imperial Palace, but… no one ever managed to establish what he'd done in the past.

Even so, she hadn't objected when he joined their group, for two reasons.

First, though he'd joined them late, Great Sir had risked his life alongside them in Gansu and Qinghai. They had built a fair measure of trust by now.

Second, even if he was a hidden blade planted by Dark Heaven, he posed no threat to them now.

As far as Bow Saint could tell, Great Sir had only just entered the Supreme Peak realm. An extraordinary achievement in its own right, but compared with the rest of their group, *only* was fair.

Too blunt to be a hidden blade. Too careless to be a spy.

That was why she'd kept him close. She understood so little about him that, even now, she couldn't quite let go of her faint suspicion.

Great Sir stared blankly at her for a moment, then suddenly clapped his hands.

"Oh, right! I came here because of you, Young Lady."

"What do you mean?"

"About half an hour ago, I finished scouting the area like I was told and went back to the carriage. I hadn't even sat down before I got kicked out again."

His voice had been half tearful. Now he lowered it.

"You know the fellow with the bright red beard and the temper to match? What was his name?"

"…Great Hero Jeok Cheongang?"

"Great Hero, my foot. If that man's a Great Hero, then this lady's a fairy. Anyway, he was furious and told me to hurry up and find you. Sounded like something important had happened."

Bow Saint felt the tension go out of her.

"What's this important thing?"

"How should I know? I told you, I didn't even get to sit down. And after coming all this way, I got hit by your palm without a shred of mercy!"

"Sorry. I mistook you for an enemy."

Great Sir was stamping his feet, apparently growing angrier as he spoke. Bow Saint calmed him, then slowly settled her internal energy.

She'd have to check his story when they got back, but he didn't seem to be lying.

At least, not here and now.

“But what were you thinking about so deeply? You looked so cheerful from behind that I was going to call out, but I held back. That’s why you mistook me for an enemy, I suppose.”

Caught off guard yet again by his bizarre words, Bow Saint let out a quiet laugh.

“Did I really look cheerful?”

“You did. Standing there alone in the faint moonlight, you looked so bright and full of life… Hm. Did I get that wrong?”

“No, you’re right. What else?”

“You seemed to be muttering something, but I couldn’t make it out. Your voice was too quiet.”

That was a relief. It hadn’t been anything too serious, but it wasn’t something she wanted anyone else to hear.

It was her secret. No one could know it. And yet, someday, she would have to make a choice.

But Great Sir wasn’t finished.

“Who were you thinking about?”

Her foot stopped in midair as she was about to step forward. Slowly, she lowered it until it pressed into the sand.

“What do you mean?”

Bow Saint tried to keep her voice steady. Great Sir studied her.

His mind might be as clouded as an overcast sky, but his eyes were as clear and bright as a midsummer day.

“I don’t know, either. But… you were definitely missing someone. And you were suffering at the same time.”

“…!”

For an instant, Bow Saint’s eyes trembled.

His voice seemed to cut through her thoughts like a blade. Yet it wasn’t simply painful. It felt like cold water washing a wound left to fester far too long.

Perhaps that was why her lips, which had seemed sealed forever, suddenly parted.

Perhaps it was because the only person with her in this lonely desert beneath the dim moon was an eccentric who had forgotten his own name and would remember nothing by tomorrow.

Or perhaps that was all just an excuse.

“That’s right.”

“I knew it! What do you think of this lady’s eye for people?”

Great Sir looked as delighted as a child. Bow Saint laughed softly—a genuine laugh that would have startled anyone else in their group.

“You were right. So right I almost wondered if you were the same person I’ve known all this time.”

“It comes from experience. I don’t remember much, but I think I was quite popular in my younger days—with men and women, young and old. Anyway, who is it? This person you miss?”

“It’s a secret.”

“A secret? I like that.”

Great Sir rubbed his palms together eagerly and asked, “Were you in love with him?”

After a moment’s silence, Bow Saint shook her head.

“I respected and admired him. Like everyone else.”

“Oh, dear. It seems you never told him how you felt. What a shame.”

“I told you, that isn’t it.”

“Words are only words. When words and actions differ, the actions are the truth. You hesitated just now.”

“…!”

“Hesitation always leads to regret. And regret can sometimes lead to the wrong choice. But everyone has a chance to choose. You may not be able to gather up every drop of spilled water, but you can wipe it away.”

Was this what it felt like to have ice-cold water poured over her?

As though waking from a brief dream, Bow Saint stared at him with wide eyes.

“You…”

She wanted to ask who he really was, and how an eccentric like him could speak with such profound insight.

But before she could finish, Great Sir leaned in and whispered.

“So confess before it’s too late. Soon—no, today would be best.”

“What?”

“Oh, don’t take me for a fool. This lady knew it all along. You’re deeply interested in that ill-tempered man’s Disciple.”

For a moment, Bow Saint couldn’t make sense of what he’d said. Then she managed to speak.

“…You mean Jin Taekyung?”

“Of course I—hm. You said it was a secret. I’ll keep that part to myself.”

“…”

“There’s no need to be embarrassed. Just go for it. It’ll be a relief! Sure, that fellow’s good at martial arts and comes from a good family, but you’ve got nothing to envy there. I hear your family’s Escort Bureau is doing well, too.”

That explained everything. Even why a man old enough to be her son had been calling her Young Lady.

Bow Saint squeezed her eyes shut. She forced down a great many thoughts and feelings before answering.

“That isn’t me.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. I heard it from someone and everything… Hm?”

Great Sir stopped. He rubbed his eyes with his sleeve, then regarded her with sudden gravity.

“Why are you here, heroine?”

“…!”

“Oh, right. That ill-tempered man—no, Great Hero Jeok told me to bring you over.”

With the composure of a Bodhisattva[3942] on the verge of enlightenment, Bow Saint replied, “Let’s go. Now, please. I won’t even ask what’s so important.”

“I’m curious myself.”

But Bow Saint never reached true enlightenment. At Great Sir’s next words, she felt the thread of her reason snap.

“I wonder if something’s happened. Jin Taekyung was looking for you, too. He seemed full of energy after sleeping for a whole month.”

Bow Saint stood frozen like a statue as Great Sir ambled away.

He glanced toward the far side of the still-clouded sky and murmured, too softly for Bow Saint to hear through the hundred and eight afflictions[3943] crowding her mind.

“A downpour’s coming.”

[3942] In Buddhism, a Bodhisattva seeks enlightenment while helping other beings attain it.

[3943] The hundred and eight afflictions are, in Buddhist tradition, the desires and mental disturbances that hinder enlightenment.

Chapter 1180

Great Sir's final mutter, heard only by the desert and the darkness, had been half right and half wrong.

As the dim dawn mist receded and the first light began to spread, the sky unleashed a downpour with all its might, as if it had been waiting for this moment.

Not over the parched desert, but toward the western plateau.

Whoooosh!

Rain came down in sheets. People pulled their collars tight and their straw rain capes close against the fierce wind and rain. The beasts carrying them let out weary cries.

"It's coming down like crazy. At this rate, forget the people—the horses won't hold out."

At the deep voice from beneath an oil-treated bamboo hat, the young man riding slowly to the speaker's right spoke up.

"We're lucky they've held out this long. We'll be clear of this wretched plateau in half a day, so we'll just have to keep going a little longer."

Wretched.

The man in the bamboo hat couldn't help agreeing. He was certain the tens of thousands of martial artists trudging forward at that very moment felt the same way.

"Yes. It hasn't been easy."

He murmured the words to himself, remembering what he'd seen on the way here.

Dry rivers and dead forests.

Villages and cities—proof that people had once lived there, yet so desolate it was hard to believe anyone ever had.

Every well was rotten. They'd searched the surrounding areas thoroughly, but found no people—not even the corpse of a common flying insect.

As if none had ever existed in the first place.

What on earth happened here?

The man in the bamboo hat thought again of the question that had long gone unanswered. But he already knew that no matter how deeply he pondered it, he'd only be wasting his mental strength.

If it were something he could figure out on his own, the white-haired old man approaching now with a nod of greeting would surely have figured it out too.

"Great Hero Song."

At the man's respectful salute, Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox, smiled.

“Family Head Jin, such formality leaves this old man hardly knowing what to do with himself. Just call me Chief.”

The man in the bamboo hat—Jin Wikyung—shook his head awkwardly.

“Compared to you, I’m still a junior by a long way. Besides, I’m only the Lesser Family Head acting in the Family Head’s place.”

“I know that, of course. But these are precisely the times when a family’s unity matters most. And the Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan…”

“He’s away. Still.”

At the young man’s abrupt interruption, Jin Wikyung clicked his tongue.

“Second.”

The Second Young Master of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, Jin Mukyung—the Heaven Shaking Sword—replied, “Who are you calling Second?”

“…Fine. Commander of the Heaven Shaking Squad.”

“Give your order.”

“Choose some men and search the surrounding area. No—Commander, please see to it. I need to speak privately with Great Hero Song.”

“Commander Jin Mukyung accepts the Family Head’s order.”

“You…!”

“Then I’ll be off.”

Without giving Jin Wikyung a chance to say another word, Jin Mukyung answered as casually as could be and disappeared into the rain, his long robe whipping behind him.

“Whew. That boy…”

At Jin Wikyung’s sigh, the Thousand-Faced Fox let out a quiet chuckle.

“Don’t be too hard on him. From what I’ve heard, you brothers are close. It’s good to see.”

“No, my younger brother needs a good scolding. He has no manners at all, interrupting an elder while he’s speaking.”

“Don’t mind me. I’m quite all rig—”

“And he didn’t even bring an umbrella.”

“Pardon?”

“It’s pouring! I’ve told him over and over to use one, and he won’t listen! He didn’t even put on a bamboo hat!”

“…”

“He won’t lose his hair right this instant, fine! But what if he catches a cold? What then, hm? Am I wrong?”

The Thousand-Faced Fox fell silent at Jin Wikyung’s sudden outburst before replying.

“You really are… close. Closer than I’d heard.”

“My younger brothers were frail when they were little. Taekyung must be having a hard time right now, too. I worry whether he’s taking care of himself.”

By this point, the Thousand-Faced Fox was worried too.

Worried that there might be something wrong with Jin Wikyung’s mind.

Who was Jin Mukyung, the Heaven Shaking Sword?

Since childhood, he’d been counted among the finest rising martial artists in Murim on the strength of his extraordinary talent alone. And after One-Ride Heavenly Dragon Murong Yeonghwi vanished with the downfall of his family, no one had denied Mukyung his place at the head of the Ten Dragons and Phoenixes.

To be precise, he had long since surpassed the level of a young prodigy.

In the recent Battle of Eight Spring Gorge, which decided the fate of the entire northern region, that young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan had defeated the Blood Soul Fat Demon, a great fiend of the previous generation, announcing the birth of a new Supreme Peak master to the world.

And Jin Wikyung was worried he’d catch a cold.

When he brought up Jin Taekyung, that monster among monsters, the Thousand-Faced Fox nearly lost the power of speech altogether.

Is he joking?

He briefly wondered whether he ought to laugh. Then, with the practiced skill of the Chief of the Hidden Shadow Pavilion, he kept his expression in check.

“Jin Taekyung will be fine. Even if he runs into a little trouble, I’m sure it won’t amount to much.”

“On that score, I’m reassured.”

Jin Wikyung, who doted on both his younger brothers—and especially his youngest, who’d long been a source of worry to him—agreed with heartfelt sincerity.

The group sent across the desert was small, given the terrain and the need for speed. But it included no fewer than six Supreme Peak masters: an elite force by any measure.

Three of them were hardly inferior to Mae Jonghak, the current Sword Saint and Alliance Leader of Murim. Even if a major threat arose, they should each be capable of protecting themselves.

If Jin Wikyung had one concern, it was a single person.

Great Sir, was it?

He’d heard plenty of rumors.

The appearance of a new Supreme Peak master always drew attention, even while Dark Heaven’s schemes shook the land.

If anything, it drew more attention now.

A mysterious master appearing in such troubled times, with wild hair and half his mind seemingly elsewhere?

A chivalrous hero who'd crushed the mounted bandits running rampant in Gansu more than a decade ago, all in one stroke?

That was all it took.

The martial world's gossips were all shouting, "I can't resist this!" as they talked about Great Sir until their mouths were dry, and word of him spread across the land.

But rumors aren't worth much in the end.

As the man leading a family, Jin Wikyung was cautious in all things. When it came to his younger brothers' safety, he left nothing to chance.

So of course he'd decided to meet the suspicious eccentric who'd joined his youngest brother's group himself.

Though, in the end, he hadn't managed it.

I wish I'd had a little more time.

Great Sir was like the wind on the Great Steppe.

Jin Wikyung had seen him only briefly, standing beside Jin Taekyung atop the city wall. After that, he was always vanishing somewhere and suddenly turning up somewhere else.

If Great Sir's whereabouts had ever remained a mystery for long, Jin Wikyung might have seriously suspected him of being a spy. But his own fairly thorough investigation had ruled that out.

Great Sir announced his presence to the world with booming nonsense and a foul stench.

Just before the army set out, Jin Wikyung had been so busy he could barely find a moment to visit his quarters. Great Sir had been elsewhere, drinking with the Beggars' Sect Leader and being invited to join the sect. When even that hadn't worked out, he'd sent Jin Mukyung and other family members in his place, only to find Great Sir hiding with Cheongpung in the military supply warehouse, looking for snacks.

And most people liked Great Sir.

Even his youngest brother did, though Jin Wikyung thought the boy was every bit as finicky as his master, familial affection aside.

"Great Sir? I don't know him that well, but from what I've seen, he seems like a good person."

"Come now, youngest! How many times have I told you to be careful around people you don't know—"

"I've been watching him since Gansu, and I've thought it over. I've got a good

feeling about him. Like I do about you, hyung[3944].”

“…Like me?”

“Don’t make that face. Of course I like you more, hyung[3945]. There’s no comparison.”

“Oh, right?”

“Of course. But hyung[3946], want some candy? Cheongpung left it behind.”

“Hm? Sure!”

That was the last time.

Time was pressing; fifteen minutes felt like three autumns. Jin Wikyung grew busier still, while Great Sir continued darting about like the wind.

Before long, the combined army of the government and Murim—the first of its kind in the continent’s history—split into three forces at the border between Qinghai and Xinjiang.

Two like enormous waves, and one like a sharp awl.

“…That candy was good.”

Jin Wikyung murmured without realizing it. Then he felt a hot stare on his cheek and composed his expression.

“Ah, pardon me. I was deep in thought about where the Imperial Army might be by now.”

At that remarkably shameless answer, Song Ho fell silent for a moment.

He was old and missing a leg, but he still had both ears, and his hearing was as sharp as ever.

He wanted to ask what candy Jin Wikyung had been enjoying so much, but the Thousand-Faced Fox once again put his years of experience to work and answered as calmly as he could.

“If all has gone according to plan, they crossed Lop Nur fifteen days ago and should be at Hejing by now.”

“Then…”

“Yes. Tianshan is close. We may be a day apart, but we should be able to join them at the edge of the Tianshan Mountains before sunset the day after tomorrow.”

“…!”

Tianshan Mountains.

The moment he heard the name, Jin Wikyung felt his grip tighten on the reins.

Tianshan, a giant of earth reaching closer to the heavens than any other.

[3944] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older man.
[3945] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older man.
[3946] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

The lair of darkness, an unfathomable demon-slaying battleground that had poured forth countless evils over a thousand years, yet whose depths remained impossible to gauge.

But at last.

They had come. At the end of this long journey, *he* was waiting.

But before Jin Wikyung could calm the shiver of awe and fear that thought sent through him, a familiar voice rang out in the distance.

"Hyung[3947]!"

Jin Mukyung. It was him.

Jin Wikyung's eyes widened as his younger brother came hurtling toward him alone like an arrow, using his lightness skill. Where had he left the horse he'd treated like an extension of himself until now?

And then Jin Wikyung saw it.

An unfamiliar landscape spread behind Jin Mukyung's approaching shoulder.

A mountain range?

A shape the deep darkness couldn't conceal.

Beyond the driving rain, it was enormous. Vast.

Is that Tianshan? The one I've heard so much about?

But why was his heart pounding so hard? Why did Jin Mukyung's cry sound so urgent?

The next moment, Jin Wikyung understood.

Or rather, a single enormous bolt of lightning, slashing down through the distant sky, showed him.

Rumble!

As the thunder boomed and a flash of light flared for an instant, the roars of countless monsters rang out.

[3947] *Hyung* is a Korean term a younger man uses for an older brother or a close older man.

Chapter 1181

For a brief moment, it was as if the world had stopped.

Eyes wide with shock. Lips hanging open in a daze.

At the end of countless gazes, a wave of calamity poured over the distant, winding hills of the plateau, blackening them beneath its tide.

Graaah!

A rumble seemed to rise from the depths of an abyss.

The vast shadow everyone had believed to be a mountain roared—the countless monsters crouched within it.

The earth shook. Torrential rain burst from the sky. They planted a chill in their enemies even deeper than the cold air of the plateau that touched the heavens.

And the name of that chill was fear.

Rumble, rumble, rumble!

People stood frozen, staring at the impossible sight.

Tens of thousands. Perhaps hundreds of thousands.

An unfathomable number of monsters charged forward, their eyes gleaming red.

Some had human faces and the limbs of tigers. Others had bodies larger than pavilions, with dozens of faces hanging from them. One shadow even spread wings unmistakably like an eagle's and swept across the sky.

"…Primordial Heavenly Venerable."[3948]

The dazed mutter that slipped from one Daoist's lips spoke for everyone.

Anyone who'd glimpsed the enemy in that flash of lightning couldn't help but think of a god.

They didn't know the exact name or form of that mighty being who must exist somewhere among the clouds and stars. What did such a trivial detail matter?

You long for light most desperately when you're trapped in pitch darkness.

Just like now.

So this was it…!

Jin Wikyung gritted his teeth.

The ruined city. The absence of any trace of life.

The answers to every question he'd asked came rushing toward them, hundreds of zhang[3949] away, so clear and horrifying that they became reality.

Straight toward the Murim allied forces' vanguard. Straight toward where they stood.

"Great Hero Song."

[3948] The Primordial Heavenly Venerable is one of the Three Pure Ones, the highest deities in Daoism.

[3949] A Chinese *zhang* is about 3.03 meters (9.94 ft).

The meaning in the quiet call was clear. Song Ho, the Thousand-Faced Fox, nodded and hurled a small cylinder with all his might. No one knew when he'd taken it from inside his robes.

Boom!

A signal firework made by the artisans of the Sichuan Tang Clan burst in a dazzling explosion.

Through the sparks drifting slowly down and painting the sky, the hideous monsters appeared once more.

Yet the light was bright enough to be seen from the rear of the army, more than ten li[3950] away, and the fierce blast briefly washed away the people's fear.

Jin Wikyung knew what he had to do now.

We have to buy time until reinforcements arrive.

Even the tightest net loosens over time.

The Murim allied forces had set out with enough momentum to bring down Tianshan in a single stroke. But after a month of nonstop advance with no chance to catch their breath, they were already exhausted. The barren land and lack of food had pushed them to their limits.

Their fatigue had piled up, and their march—once as steady as an unobstructed river—had begun to falter.

It was terrible luck that this happened while the Jin Family of Taiyuan, one of the weaker forces in the alliance, was briefly holding the vanguard. But they were fortunate in one respect: Jin Wikyung was leading them.

His martial arts might not match those of his two younger brothers, but everyone acknowledged him as a leader.

"I, Jin Wikyung, Lesser Family Head of the Jin Family of Taiyuan, ask you this!"

His shout, infused with Peak internal energy, shook the plateau. His eyes blazed like torches.

"What are you so afraid of!"

Those who'd instinctively begun to retreat stopped in their tracks.

But that alone couldn't overcome the fear gripping them. Jin Wikyung met the eyes turned toward him and shouted again.

"What did you come here for!"

Feet that had stopped began moving forward again. Trembling fingers closed around sword hilts.

They all knew the answer.

For the world. For the greater cause.

To protect what they held dear, or to avenge what they'd already lost.

That was why they'd stood beneath one banner and prepared to face death.

[3950] A Chinese *li* is about 500 meters (0.311 mi); ten li is about 5 kilometers (3.1 mi).

“Neither I nor any of you came here as martial artists!”

The ground trembled harder. Jin Wikyung’s voice rang out with rising force.

“We stand here as human beings! As someone’s children, as someone’s parents, here to protect what’s ours!”

The frightened horses snorted fiercely. He could see faces clouded by exhaustion of body and mind.

And yet—

Even so—

“Face them with your heads held high! If you can’t cast off your fear, cut it down along with the enemy!”

Clang, clang, clang!

As if breaking chains around their wrists, they drew their weapons.

Together, they pointed them toward the wave of monsters, now a little over a hundred zhang away.

Their breathing quickened, white puffs spilling from their mouths.

Their mouths felt gritty, as though they’d chewed a handful of sand. Their hearts hammered as if they might burst.

But no one retreated now.

Even as the horses that couldn’t overcome their fear broke free of their masters and bolted in every direction.

Not when the hundred-odd zhang between them shrank by half, then half again.

Not even when a giant monster, its height level with the pavilions of a great city, tore a massive boulder from where it lay embedded in the plateau and hurled it at them.

Whoooosh!

For an instant, the rain stopped.

No—the great boulder overhead had blocked the rain falling on them.

“Ah…!”

Someone cried out. Jin Wikyung’s tightly closed lips parted.

“Second brother.”

Shing!

A ray of blue, bluer than a cloudless sky, shot upward.

It was quiet, and it was sharp.

Sharp enough to cut through raindrops, wind, and air—and even a thousand-geun[3951] boulder that had lain there for centuries—in a single silent stroke.

Slice!

[3951] A *geun* is a Korean unit of weight equal to about 600 grams (1.32 lb). A thousand geun is about 600 kilograms (1,320 lb).

A flash like lightning blazed, and it was over.

Blue Wave, Falling Bird.

The blue wave surging from one man's sword split the enormous boulder—not a bird—into dozens of pieces and sent them tumbling down the hill.

Rumble!

Through rain so heavy that not even a cloud of dust could rise, the young Sword Demon of the Jin Family of Taiyuan returned, having finally shaken off the monsters pursuing him. He muttered under his breath.

"I told you I'm the Commander of the Heaven Shaking Squad."

Jin Wikyung smiled faintly.

"I thought you called me 'hyungnim'[3952] a moment ago."

"…You must have imagined it."

"Oh dear. I must have misheard."

Jin Wikyung answered gently, as if soothing a child, and handed him a bamboo hat.

"Put it on. You'll catch a cold."

Jin Mukyung sighed softly at his older brother's tone and accepted the hat.

Once he'd tied the oil-treated bamboo hat's chin strap tight, the driving rain no longer obscured his vision.

But why did the world look so pitch-black now that he could see it clearly?

Rumble!

The earth shuddered beneath the darkness pouring in from every direction.

The monsters showed no sign of slowing. Jin Mukyung stared at the countless creatures charging toward him and tightened his grip on his sword hilt.

His breathing was steady, his gaze composed.

There wasn't a trace of fear in him.

Not because he was confident he'd win this battle.

He simply had a reason to fight, and faith in that reason. That was why he didn't waver.

That's right. I believe in him. We all do.

Jin Mukyung thought of one person.

His younger brother, whose whole life had changed overnight—and who had then changed everything around him.

He wasn't here, but that was a good thing.

The more monsters filled the view before them, the smaller the threat to Jin Taekyung would be.

[3952] *Hyungnim* is a respectful Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older man he regards as one.

That guy, at least, has to survive to the end.

Jin Mukyung took a deep breath, stepped out of the tightly formed defensive formation, and walked forward.

That single step closed the last distance between humans and monsters.

Whoooosh!

A monster's enormous fist plunged down with a fierce burst of air. Its horrible stench seeped deep into his nose, but he didn't care.

Whatever the outcome of this battle, by the time it was over, the stench of blood would blanket the entire plateau—worse than anything he smelled now.

Shhhhh.

Blue Wave.

True to its name, a blue wave of Force surged up once again.

It silently carved apart the fist bearing down on them, swallowing the monsters at the front whole.

Crunch!

Severed limbs and blood sprayed in every direction.

The monsters, no longer human or beast, collapsed with mournful final cries.

But why?

The stench rising from their rotting bodies wasn't as foul as the one Jin Mukyung had smelled before. And a new light was layered over the blue Sword Force that blazed through the surroundings, illuminating and tearing through everything in its path.

Like the sunset gently coloring the world as the sun slowly sank.

Or a flower petal drifting on a breeze from nowhere.

Ah.

As the realization sounded within him, Jin Mukyung understood what this strange yet warm power was.

He knew, too, whose purple Force had slipped quietly onto the battlefield like a passing breeze.

Swish.

The hem of a robe fluttered in midair.

No one had noticed exactly when he appeared or how he'd moved.

Not even Jin Mukyung.

All that remained was the rich scent of plum blossoms, lingering at the tip of his nose and erasing even the monsters' stench.

"Good. I'm not too late."

Having reached the pinnacle of the sword long ago, he was the Number One Sword Under Heaven. With no one beneath this vast sky who could compare to him, he was the brightest star above the clouds.

The Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, spoke, his eyes sinking deep.

“Then let’s begin.”

At that moment—

Fwoosh!

Above the purple plum blossoms that finally bloomed and scattered, the Sect Leaders of the Nine Sects and One Gang and the heads of the Five Great Families plunged down like meteors, led by four of the Ten Kings.

Boom!

Deep darkness and dazzling beams of light began tearing into each other with all their might.

Chapter 1182

The thick mist of blood spreading in every direction wasn't confined to the plateau west of the desert.

A thousand li[3953] to the east, the scene unfolding in a basin was just as brutal.

No—it was all too similar.

Crunch!

The battle was fierce.

And desperate.

Through the torrential rain, heavy enough to obscure the field, blood and chunks of flesh flew—no one could tell whose. Long, razor-sharp claws like scythes and finely honed spears and blades rushed at one another.

Clang!

Sparks flew. Monsters twice the size of grown men charged with furious roars.

Graaah!

Arms and legs thick as logs. Three or four heads hanging from each rotting body.

The sight alone was enough to send a primal chill down anyone's spine. But a low, deep sound rang out the next moment and snapped the soldiers back to their senses.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

A war drum.

Dozens of strongmen struck it with all their might, its thunderous beat shaking the vast basin.

It thawed frozen hands and feet and breathed life into courage that had begun to fade.

"Defend!"

A flag snapped at the shouted command.

Tens of thousands of troops moved as one.

The monsters' claws tore into iron-plated shields instead of human flesh and bone. Spearmen packed together like the spines of a hedgehog thrust their long spears, each a zhang[3954] in length.

Crack! Splurt!

Fountains of blood erupted across the field.

But it wasn't only the enemy's blood.

[3953] In this Chinese setting, one *li* is about 500 m (0.311 mi); a thousand *li* is about 500 km (311 mi).

[3954] One *zhang*, a traditional Chinese unit of length, is about 3.03 m (9.94 ft).

Many of the monsters didn't suffer so much as a scratch from the sharpened spearheads. They smashed through the shield wall and leaped into the broken ranks.

Whoosh! Boom!

Clods of earth burst into the air.

Bodies that had been full of strength a moment ago were flung away as mere chunks of flesh. Those who witnessed the unreal sight remembered the fear they'd briefly forgotten.

And right then—

Shing!

Dozens of streaks of light plunged down from above, blocking the monsters' relentless charge.

No.

They cut them down.

Slice! Splatter!

The soldiers at the front, who'd only just escaped death, stared wide-eyed at green blood spreading like mist.

More precisely, they stared at the shadows descending over the monsters' severed corpses.

At the golden armor shining almost unnaturally bright—and the man standing tall amid those Embroidered Uniform Guards.

"Your Majesty!"

They cried out with unmistakable loyalty and reverence.

They called to the sole ruler of the Nine Provinces and Eight Wastes, the Four Seas and Five Lakes. To the father who governed all under heaven in accordance with the will of Heaven.

And the Son of Heaven of the Great Ming Empire, Zhu Di, answered their call.

In the most effective way he could at that moment.

Thud!

A monster plunging from the sky like a bolt of lightning, its unmistakably hawklike wings folded tight, shuddered.

"Who do you think you're attacking?"

The Son of Heaven spoke with astonishing calm as he twisted the sword buried deep between the monster's brows.

"But you, too, were once one of my people."

Crack.

"Rest in peace."

With one final, wet crunch, the monster stopped moving. The tens of thousands of Imperial Guards watching felt something hot rise from deep in their bellies.

Who was the Son of Heaven?

Their lord. The master of the continent.

And yet this supreme being, whom they scarcely dared look upon, was fighting alongside them.

Shoulder to shoulder, drenched in the enemy's blood.

Someone else might scoff and ask if that was all it took. But to them, it was everything.

Everything they needed to willingly give their lives.

"Long live Your Majesty!"

"Long live the Great Ming Empire!"

Hundreds of voices became thousands, then tens of thousands. At last, one unified roar rose as the Imperial Army charged.

The Son of Heaven watched them go in silence.

Until a young officer guarding him nearby spoke.

"Your Majesty, may this humble officer dare to say something?"

The Son of Heaven shook his head.

"Denied."

He answered without a moment's hesitation.

But the young officer didn't back down.

"Please return. It's dangerous here."

"Did you not hear what I said?"

"I heard you clearly."

"Then how do you intend to answer for this crime?"

"I will accept any punishment. But I beg Your Majesty to preserve your sacred person first and carry out the sentence afterward."

The young officer was respectful yet unflinching. The Son of Heaven let out a quiet laugh.

"A mere Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard dares to defy my word. The laws of the imperial house must have fallen into disarray. Wouldn't you agree?"

A middle-aged man who had appeared out of nowhere spoke up.

"Wouldn't it be a hundred times better for its laws to fall into disarray than for the imperial house itself to fall?"

It was a disrespectful answer that could have seen him branded a traitor on the spot. Yet the Son of Heaven didn't so much as raise an eyebrow.

The middle-aged man holding a silver crescent-bladed halberd had done more than anyone under heaven to protect the imperial house.

"You came, Baek Yeon."

Baek Yeon, Commander of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, gave a brief military salute and corrected him.

“I had to.”

“How strange. No one called for you—not even me.”

“Then why is Your Majesty, who ought to be safely in the rear, here?”

“For the same reason you came here of your own accord.”

Baek Yeon paused, then gave a dry laugh.

“You’ve answered a foolish question with a wise reply. I have nothing more to say.”

Yes. It had been a foolish question.

Just as Baek Yeon had come to protect the Son of Heaven, the Son of Heaven had come to protect the people who followed him.

Not for some grand cause, but out of compassion for his people.

Compassion. Compassion…

It was a word he hadn’t thought of in a long time.

The Empire’s fourth prince, who had once raced across battlefields with hot blood and a natural gift for war, had disappeared after Dark Heaven’s shadow fell over the imperial house.

The Son of Heaven had to be cold. He had to be heartless. He’d believed it was the right course—the only way to solve every problem.

At least until a few months ago, when he met one man.

Jin Taekyung.

He was utterly free-spirited.

No matter what stood in his way, he pushed forward with all his strength.

Simply because he was brave?

No.

He felt fear and pain just like everyone else—perhaps even more than they did. But he pressed on because he believed it was the compassionate thing to do.

The path Jin Taekyung walked was narrow, but straight.

And in the end, it reached everyone. It had brought countless people all the way here.

“He’s better than I am. Enough to make me ashamed to be the Son of Heaven.”

That mutter would have thrown the court into an uproar had the civil and military officials heard it. The Son of Heaven raised the sword he’d let hang at his side.

Then he turned to the young Embroidered Uniform Guard officer who had tried to stop him.

“Has your resolve still not changed?”

The officer replied in a steady voice.

“With all due respect, no.”

“Very well. I will withdraw in accordance with your wishes, at once. In return, you are not to leave my side for even a moment.”

The officer faltered at the unexpected words. The Son of Heaven added, his voice strong,

“But we will withdraw forward, not back.”

“Your Majesty.”

“I am the Son of Heaven. The father of all the people. A father never turns away from his children when they’re bleeding. That is the will of Heaven.”

“…!”

“I ask you again. Has your resolve still not changed?”

After a moment’s silence, the young officer knelt.

“I, Jeong Hogun, Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard, receive the command of Your Majesty, the august Emperor.”

“Follow me. We’ll open a path.”

“As you command!”

Jeong Hogun wasn’t the only one to answer.

The thousand Embroidered Uniform Guards who had closed ranks around the Son of Heaven roared as one, shaking the battlefield.

Their cry swept over the heads of the Imperial Guards, whose lines were rapidly collapsing under the overwhelming odds, and reached even the true enemy lying in wait beyond them.

Pitch-black armor reflected no light. Each movement brought a dull, heavy sound.

Red eyes glowed beneath helmets pulled low, and the mouths visible below them reeked of corpse stench.

“Black Ghosts…!”

True monsters, each one the equal of a Supreme Peak master.

Countless eyes trembled at the sight of no fewer than twenty of them. Then a thunderous cry burst from the Son of Heaven’s lips.

“I command the Twelve Palaces!”

At that very moment—

Crunch!

More than ten streaks of light shot up across the battlefield.

Twelve men and women crushed the monsters in their path and reached the Son of Heaven in an instant. They bowed deeply before him.

The pillars and stars that upheld and illuminated the imperial house: the Twelve Palaces of the Zodiac.

After the bloodshed in the imperial palace, these Supreme Peak masters had been newly organized under the Son of Heaven's command as a force directly serving the imperial house. Their eyes shone as they looked to their lord.

"Give your command."

The Son of Heaven took a deep breath.

When this battle was over, how many of them would still be alive?

No—could anyone even dare to predict victory against enemies so terrifyingly powerful?

What would the old me have done?

He already knew the answer to the question that had suddenly come to mind.

He would have retreated without hesitation.

Even if it meant sending tens of thousands of Imperial Guards to their deaths.

But the actions of one man had changed more than just this world.

The Son of Heaven had been reborn, too.

Though accepting the Maoshan Sect's martial arts had left his body little different from a dead man's, his heart and blood burned hotter than ever.

Like everyone else here.

Just like the man who'd awakened him once again: Jin Taekyung.

And if Jin Taekyung were here, he would surely say this:

"Wipe them all out."

The words held not a trace of decorum, and that made the freedom in them all the clearer. The Son of Heaven raced across the blood-soaked earth.

Whoooosh!

A brilliant golden wave stretched out behind him like the tail of a meteor.

Jin Taekyung suddenly raised his head.

Two streaks of light were crossing the sky, which had turned black before he'd noticed.

A meteor?

It wasn't exactly common, but it wasn't all that rare, either.

So why?

Jin Taekyung pressed down on his throbbing chest.

For a long time, he couldn't manage a proper night's sleep.

Not after night gave way to dawn and the first light appeared. Not after he and his companions finally left that damned desert behind.

Not even after they passed through mountains and fields blanketed in perennial snow and reached the place where all the allied forces were supposed to rendezvous.

No one came.

A day passed, then another.

Chapter 1183

It was a nameless ruin.

Judging by its size and the number of buildings, it had once been a small city where several thousand households lived. But as everyone had expected, there was not a person to be found.

Only the mountain range stretching endlessly along the distant horizon remained to watch over the ghost town.

The Tianshan Mountains: a giant of nature wearing a bamboo hat of snow that never melted, no matter the season.

The mountains of heaven, huh.

Muttering to myself, I gazed through the window at the vast landscape.

Overwhelming. Almost awe-inspiring.

It was a sight that could only be called Tianshan. The peaks rose through the clouds, high enough that I could almost imagine immortals living somewhere up there.

No, that wasn't such an absurd fantasy.

Replace *immortals* with *Demon King*, and fantasy became reality.

A very horrifying reality, at that.

"Captain?"

A voice suddenly pierced my ear.

Plenty of people called me their benefactor. Only one called me Captain.

I kept my eyes on the view outside. "Yeah."

Maybe it was because my thoughts were tangled like a ball of string. My voice came out subdued, and Hyuk Mujin hesitated before speaking again.

"Um, have you eaten?"

"Sort of. Why?"

"Slau—no, Great Hero Mungyeong told me to stop by if I had a chance. He wanted to make sure you weren't skipping meals."

"He did? That's unusual."

It surprised me a little. We'd grown close during our time together, but I hadn't thought he was the sort to worry about whether I'd eaten.

"He said these are special fasting pills he made before we set out, just in case. We're running low on food already, and he said he'd kill you if you left any."

"…Yeah, that sounds more like him."

I shook my head and took the fasting pill I'd tucked away in my clothes. Hyuk Mujin's eyes turned cold.

"You said you ate."

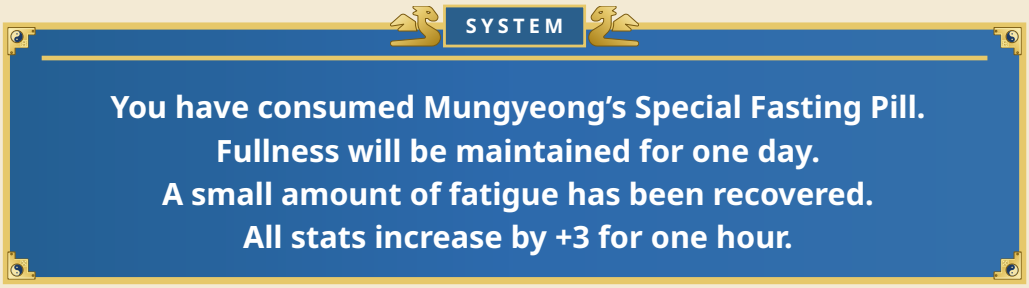
"I said *sort of*. I didn't say I ate."

"Honestly. I knew it."

Maybe he was acting up because he hadn't been hit enough lately.

Ignoring his grumbling, I popped the pill into my mouth. I chewed and swallowed through a bitterness I couldn't begin to identify. Then, along with a surprising feeling of fullness, a System notification rang out.

Ding.



It tasted like shit, but it certainly worked.

Though for something made by the Divine Physician, its effects were a little disappointing.

I grimaced and smacked my lips. Then I met Hyuk Mujin's gaze as he stared at me with an almost uncomfortable intensity.

"What are you doing?"

"Y-yes?"

"Why are you staring? Is there something on my face?"

"Uh, no. You just look really… handsome today. Hehe."

I couldn't help a bitter smile at his ingratiating flattery.

It was obvious what he was doing. My mood had been low lately, and he was trying to cheer me up.

I didn't let on. I clicked my tongue instead.

"Enough nonsense. If you're done here, get out. Don't bother me just to make sure I eat."

"Hey, what do you mean, *just*? We're doing all this so we can keep living. What's more important than food?"

"You sound like someone I know."

"Are you seriously comparing me to Taishan, that A-Gwi of a bastard—"

His words trailed off.

Hyuk Mujin only moved his lips for a while, as though he'd said something he shouldn't have. I turned my gaze back out the window, too.

After a brief silence, his voice sounded through the dusty room, quieter than before.

"Captain."

"Go on."

"Taishan… he's doing all right, isn't he?"

"He should be."

"He eats so much, he might've cleaned out their food supply already. Sneaking food whenever he gets the chance, taking a few whacks from Old Man Nam, getting scolded by Sama Pyo…"

"Could be."

"I'm sure that's exactly what's happening. Want to bet?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because we'd both bet on the same thing."

"Oh. Right."

"Yeah."

Silence returned, longer and much heavier than before.

And this time, too, it was Hyuk Mujin—not me—who broke it first.

"Captain."

"Yeah."

"Everyone's… doing okay, right?"

I didn't answer.

Instead, I looked out at the landscape I'd watched for the past two days, a view that hadn't changed for even a moment. It was overwhelming and awe-inspiring, yet it felt utterly empty.

I wondered why a landscape filled to the last detail looked to me like a blank sheet of paper.

No.

I thought about the people.

Jin Wikyung, who would run toward me without a care for who was watching, shouting, "Youngest!" at the top of his lungs.

Jin Mukyung, watching his eldest brother rush ahead with a sullen expression.

Sama Pyo, now leading hundreds of subordinates like a proper Sect Leader, and Namho and Taishan, who had somehow become inseparable.

A Thousand Captain of the Embroidered Uniform Guard who'd thanked me with a face stiff as a block of wood—and the ruler of the continent, whose body was dead yet who seemed more full of life than before.

I thought of all of them, everyone we'd parted from with a smile in Qinghai.

I thought of the past, already gone, and the future soon to come.

But why?

We'd left the desert behind. Two days had passed, and now the sun was sinking. Still, there was no sign of them.

No Murim Alliance banners rising like mountains in the west. No golden armor surging like a tide from the east.

That was right.

I hadn't been looking at the landscape. I'd been looking for the people coming from somewhere far away.

Yet as the last day we'd agreed upon drew to a close, I still couldn't find them.

…Maybe.

I forced down the three syllables that had surfaced unbidden.

Then, as though a wave could erase the disordered sand on a beach, I repeated to myself:

No. That can't be.

They were strong.

Their blades and spears were sharp, and their resolve burned bright.

They were Murim. They were the Nine Provinces[3955] and all under Heaven.

So I held tight to the belief clenched in my fist.

This wait would be rewarded. However exhausted and dust-covered they were after their endless forced march, we would see each other again soon, smiling.

I believed it.

Believing was all I could do.

"Let's do it."

Hyuk Mujin had come up beside me without a word and was looking out the window with me. He glanced over.

"Do what?"

"That bet from earlier. Let's do it after all."

I watched the world slowly turn red and went on.

"They'll come before midnight. I'm sure of it."

Hyuk Mujin stared at me with wide eyes, then let out a quiet laugh.

"That can't be a bet."

"Why not?"

"Because we'd both bet on the same thing. That's not a bet."

"Damn. You're right."

"See?"

"So you're not doing it?"

"No."

[3955]The Nine Provinces are the traditional divisions of ancient China; the expression can refer to the realm as a whole.

He added firmly, “Of course I’m doing it.”

His voice drifted out the window on the wind.

Then the sunset weighed down on the world, and darkness came.

A darkness so still it was suffocating.

“We leave in fifteen minutes.”

A draft blew in from somewhere, making the candle flicker precariously. Jeok Cheongang’s voice and tone, however, were calm and composed.

“If we wait another day for these fools who forgot the agreed date—whether they’re from the Murim Alliance or the Imperial Guards—I’ll start producing relics[3956] inside my own body. It’d be a hundred times better for us to move ahead as scouts and vanguard.”

On the surface, it made sense.

Perhaps Jeok Cheongang’s composure made it seem even more reasonable. He spoke as though he’d expected all this from the start.

The Slaughter Saint and Bow Saint nodded on either side of him. The others listened in silence.

But Jin Taekyung was different.

“You want us to go ahead?”

“Is there another way?”

“It’s not that there’s another way. We can’t take that one.”

“Go on.”

“If we went back west and east—even a day’s travel, no, just half a day’s—we might run into our scouts…”

“Midnight has passed. The date we agreed on is behind us. We discussed what to do afterward in advance.”

“But…”

“Fool!”

Whoosh!

The air abruptly heated. His master’s sharp rebuke rang out, and he fixed his Disciple with a level gaze.

“I know what you fear, but moving armies of that size brings countless difficulties. We’re only going one step ahead according to the plan already made. No more arguing.”

[3956] *Sarira* are relics associated with the cremated remains of Buddhist practitioners. Producing them while still alive is an exaggeration for an unbearably long wait.

Normally, Jin Taekyung would have obeyed Jeok Cheongang. Their relationship might have been more informal than most between master and Disciple, but Taekyung trusted and followed him more than anyone.

Normally.

Not today. Not at this moment.

An inexplicable sense of déjà vu came over him.

What is it?

Something was wrong. No, it was more than that.

Xinjiang had long been treated as a deathtrap under the Demonic Cult's rule, but it wasn't unknown territory.

Where had the cult's immense power, fit to be called a theocratic kingdom, and the strength to fight the Murim of the Central Plains come from?

Xinjiang's vast lands held substantial manpower and resources. It had once been one of the most important trade routes under Heaven.

The Hidden Shadow Pavilion had long since obtained information about the region, including its geography. Only a few months ago, it had sent in dozens of spies, though just one had returned alive.

But the Tianshan Mountains were different.

If Xinjiang lay beneath the Demonic Cult's shadow, Tianshan was its Sacred Land: the place where the cult had first risen and put down roots.

A truly unknown land within the deathtrap of Xinjiang.

And no one had been able to reach those roots.

Yet Jeok Cheongang had just said they were merely going one step ahead according to a "plan already made."

A plan Taekyung had never heard of.

That can't be. Once we enter Tianshan, joining up with our allies will be next to impossible.

Jin Taekyung felt his heart pounding hard and heat rising inside him.

And all at once, he realized a truth he could hardly believe.

"You were lying. Just to deceive me."

Taekyung's voice trembled. Jeok Cheongang answered.

"From the beginning, only one thing was decided. If we failed to meet on the agreed date, we would advance without hesitation."

His master's heavy voice struck him like a war hammer.

"We… No. *You* are the main assault."

His master's heavy voice came crashing down over his Disciple's head like a war hammer.

Chapter 1184

“We… No. *You* are the main assault.”

“…!”

The moment Jeok Cheongang’s quiet voice reached him, Jin Taekyung went rigid.

At the same time, the fog clouding his mind finally began to lift.

But the reality emerging beyond it was neither as hopeful nor as beautiful as he’d wished.

“What… what does that mean?”

A question was supposed to express uncertainty and seek an answer that would clear it up.

But Jeok Cheongang knew there was no uncertainty in the question Taekyung had just asked. Only denial.

Taekyung wanted to hear himself deny a reality he couldn’t bear to believe.

“You already know what this old man means.”

The old master looked at his Disciple, his gaze grave. Then he spoke slowly, giving weight to every word.

“Everything we did was for us. For you.”

“…You mean—”

“Xinjiang is Dark Heaven’s domain. No, not just this land. Their eyes and ears have been hidden everywhere under Heaven. We had to consider every possibility.”

Together, they were strong. Scattered, they were vulnerable.

Even so, they hadn’t split their mighty army of more than a hundred thousand into three forces solely for practical reasons like supplies or marching speed.

“We had to keep one last dagger hidden until the very end, in case it came to that.”

That dagger was Jin Taekyung.

Not the sharpest in the world, nor the most precious—but against Dark Heaven, more lethal than any other weapon.

No. Perhaps the Lord of Heaven’s only Adversary, chosen by Heaven itself.

“That’s why everyone agreed. The Sword Saint, the Emperor. And…”

Jeok Cheongang looked around at the silent group and added,

“We did, too.”

Only then did Taekyung realize that not one person gathered here had objected.

The Slaughter Saint and the Bow Saint. Ju Hwaran and Song Ilseom. Cheongpung, Gung Gibang, even Hyuk Mujin.

Some watched him in silence, their faces dark. The others lowered their heads, unable to meet his eyes.

“You deceived me. From the very beginning.”

"I'm sorry."

Jeok Cheongang's apology was so sincere that anyone who knew him even a little would have doubted their eyes and ears.

But for Taekyung, this wasn't something an apology could settle.

A hundred thousand.

More than a hundred thousand lives were still out there, beyond the darkness outside the window. Among those whose fate was now unknown were people bound to him by ties deeper than time.

Comrades he could trust with his back. Friends he'd gladly lay down his life for. Brothers who shared no blood with him but had become family all the same.

"I'm going back."

Taekyung rose from his seat, his voice strained.

Perhaps it was the shock of what he'd just heard that churned his stomach and made his head spin. He gritted his teeth.

He had to go back and save them. Find them.

…Even if all he found were their bodies.

But before he could take a step, Jeok Cheongang's voice stopped him again.

No—it struck his frozen heart.

"Do we have time for that?"

"…!"

"The agreed date has passed. We can't hesitate any longer. If we delay even a little more, what comes next will be even harder to contain."

Those weren't just words. It was reality.

A merciless reality Taekyung understood better than anyone.

Everything was already collapsing, like a massive dam giving way.

The modern world. Murim.

Until he cleared the Quest, the bridge between the two worlds would remain broken. And nothing could turn back the flow of time, already thrown so far out of alignment.

No. There was only one way left.

Close his eyes, keep his mouth shut, and move forward.

Then, at the end of this journey, defeat the source of every disaster waiting there: the Lord of Heaven.

But…

Even if I succeed at everything, I'll regret this for the rest of my life.

That wouldn't change even if he were hailed as the savior of a new humanity and gained immense wealth and fame.

He might gain everything in the world, but it would all slip through his fingers like sand.

Even now, after all he'd accomplished, Taekyung still sometimes had nightmares.

He still trembled at the roar of the Black Wyvern—a monster he could kill with One Strike now. He still wandered through that dark cave, where his companions' screams rang out without end.

And so Taekyung made his decision.

"I'm sorry."

He steeled himself. He would go back, even if only a day's travel. Even if only half a day's.

If that half day ruined everything, he would accept it as his damnable fate.

If he couldn't save even the few people closest to him, then all of this was nothing but some being called a god playing a sick game.

Watching his Disciple, Jeok Cheongang muttered bitterly,

"So this is how it ends up."

"You know what I'm like."

"I do. That's why I took you as my Disciple."

Hearing the sincerity in his master's voice, Taekyung smiled faintly.

"I'll be back soon."

"I'm sorry."

Taekyung shook his head.

He wanted to tell his master that none of this was anyone's fault. It was simply a matter of choice; there was no need to apologize.

But for some reason, the words wouldn't leave his lips. And the step he'd already taken wasn't followed by another.

What's going on?

The question surfaced as Taekyung breathed hard.

At some point, his heart had started pounding like mad. The skin around his eyes burned as though pressed against torches, and his vision shimmered with heat haze thicker than in the midday desert.

Then, through that warped and rippling world, an unexpected voice echoed.

"No need to get worked up. You'll feel at ease soon."

A calm tone. A troubled look.

Confused as he was, Taekyung had no trouble recognizing the speaker.

"Why…?"

To the question Taekyung barely managed to force out, the Slaughter Saint returned the very words he'd spoken a moment ago.

"Because I knew what you're like."

"…!"

“And don’t blame that Hyuk brat later. He’s as stubborn as his superior. It took me ages to convince him.”

Taekyung saw Hyuk Mujin behind the Slaughter Saint, his head bowed, and finally understood.

Mujin’s odd insistence on checking that he’d taken the pill. The special fasting pills the Slaughter Saint had made.

Poison?

But something was wrong with that.

If he’d been poisoned, the System would have warned him immediately, and the Myriad-Poison Ring on his finger would have begun detoxifying him.

It was a perfectly reasonable question.

The problem was that the man before him—also known as the Divine Physician—knew those things just as well as he did.

“Poison and medicine are one and the same. Only the slightest difference separates them.”

The man who had used that slightest difference to make a medicine perilously close to poison let out a quiet sigh.

“I didn’t want to go this far. Truly.”

Taekyung answered in a cracked voice.

“I understand.”

“I’m glad to hear it.”

“Then I hope you’ll understand me, too.”

“What do you—”

The Slaughter Saint sensed something amiss and was about to ask when—

Whoom!

Taekyung’s fist came hurtling toward his face with a heavy rush of air.

Boom!

Compressed air exploded in the wake of his lightning-fast punch. The gust sent dust billowing up from the floor.

The Slaughter Saint twisted his body out of its path at the last moment, his eyes wide.

He can barely keep himself upright. How?

Taekyung’s strength and speed were hard to believe from someone who was, for all practical purposes, poisoned.

But unlike the Slaughter Saint, Taekyung had no intention of answering his question.

More precisely, he had no time.

He left the startled Slaughter Saint behind and charged through the dust cloud toward the window—only for someone else to block his path.

Shing!

Two streaks of light flashed.

At their tips lay enough force and momentum to cleave through a boulder of solid iron in a single stroke, but Jin Taekyung twisted his upper body without a moment's hesitation.

As if he'd seen it coming.

Shhk.

Blades swept past him with a low, chilling hiss.

In the same instant, he struck.

Crash!

His two palms met the Bow Saint's twin sabers.

With a boom like an exploding cannonball, the Bow Saint's sunken eyes appeared reflected on the trembling blade of her curved saber.

"Stop."

Taekyung gritted his teeth instead of answering.

Crk.

Pain shot through his jaw, jolting his fading mind awake. It lit a fire in the body that had not yet fallen asleep.

Grind.

His palms drove forward against the blades.

At the same time, the Bow Saint began to slide backward with her treasured weapon as Jin Taekyung's perfect, massive muscles flexed—too large to hide even beneath his thick robe.

It was the strength of some ancient giant. A will that refused to give out.

But that was as far as he could go.

As far as his heart and body could endure.

"I'm sorry. Truly."

The moment Jeok Cheongang's tearful voice came from behind him, Jin Taekyung felt every bit of the strength boiling inside him like lava turn cold.

Faces blurred before him, as indistinct as his vision. Memories of the time he'd spent with them rose one after another, clouding his sight more densely than any fog or dust.

Drip. Drip.

Rainwater fell from somewhere and wet the floor. At last, the old master caught his Disciple as he crumpled.

Chapter 1185

"Good. Nothing's wrong with him."

At the Slaughter Saint's first words after examining Jin Taekyung, Jeok Cheongang spoke, his face grim.

"Are you sure?"

"I guarantee it."

"That's what you told me about three shichen[3957] ago."

"Have a little faith. The medicine just took longer than expected to spread through his system."

"It's hard to trust you. Things nearly went wrong because of some quack's careless guarantee."

Their eyes met. The air seemed to tighten between them.

After a brief silence, Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet sigh.

"I went too far. I apologize."

"No need. I understand how you feel."

The Slaughter Saint truly didn't mind.

He had spent half his life as an assassin and the other half as a physician. Treating more patients than he could count had taught him more than medicine.

It had taught him about the heart.

He had come to understand the hearts of the sick, and of those closest to them who watched and shared their suffering.

That was why he knew better than anyone that the man before him was not the great martial artist known as the Fire King. He was Jeok Cheongang—a man whose Disciple lay unconscious before them, a member of the patient's family.

Besides, I failed to give him enough reason to trust me as a physician.

With that thought, the Slaughter Saint quietly studied Jin Taekyung's face. He had already lost consciousness.

And at the same time, he remembered the terrifying strength and speed Taekyung had displayed moments ago.

Everything was perfect. The medicine I prepared, the time it would take to work.

The fasting pill Taekyung had taken was the Slaughter Saint's masterpiece, painstakingly made with the Myriad-Poison Ring in mind.

At first, it was nothing more than an ordinary fasting pill. But once its effects began to spread, slowly, over more than three shichen[3958], that changed.

[3957] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.

[3958] A *shichen* is a traditional time unit of approximately two hours; three shichen is about six hours.

It would paralyze the limbs, cloud the mind and Qi Sense, and even disperse internal energy. The Slaughter Saint had been certain that no Supreme Peak master could easily withstand it.

He had thought even he would be in trouble if he took it without knowing what it was.

Then how did this brat…?

His gaze lingered on Taekyung.

Was it his imagination, or did his back still tingle where the fierce wind from Taekyung's fist had swept past? A faint doubt came with the sensation.

Had that truly been a blow delivered with all his strength?

"…Perhaps."

The word slipped out before he realized it.

Jeok Cheongang gave him a questioning look. Realizing his mistake, the Slaughter Saint shook his head at once.

"It's nothing. I was thinking about something."

"Could it be…?"

"Rest easy. I've told you more than once: there's nothing wrong with your Disciple. He'll wake within two days at the latest."

He watched Ju Hwaran and Hyuk Mujin support Taekyung as they moved him away, then added, "And by the time he wakes, we'll be somewhere out there."

Jeok Cheongang turned toward the window.

Beyond a world where even the stars had vanished, the immense Tianshan Mountains rose through the darkness like a monster from myth. They had stood there a thousand years ago and looked as though they would stand for another thousand.

But the Lord of Heaven, crouched somewhere in those mountains, was the true monster—a being worthy of being called an abyss. Defeating him would mean staking the fate of all under Heaven.

"I can't tell if this was truly the right choice," Jeok Cheongang murmured.

"You know as well as I do. This isn't the best choice, or even the second-best. It's only the lesser evil that barely lets us avoid the worst—and the only choice left to us now."

He was right. They had come too far to speak of the best choice.

Neither the Imperial Army nor the Murim Alliance had arrived by the agreed date. Only one path remained before them.

And it was one of several possibilities they had considered even before leaving Qinghai.

If no one arrives by the appointed date—if, by some chance, that happens…

Jeok Cheongang remembered the Sword Saint, Mae Jonghak, speaking quietly at their secret meeting in the dim light before dawn.

"Leave this place and go to Tianshan. Without a moment's hesitation."

"Leave? Are you serious?"

"If things went wrong despite following a plan devised by the strongest martial artists and wisest strategists under Heaven, what more is there to say? The Son of Heaven has already agreed."

"But—"

"This isn't a sacrifice. It's a choice for the sake of everyone. Whatever misfortune befalls us, we can still avoid the worst. We'll have one move left."

Do all that man can, then await Heaven's will.

They had done all they could. Now they would wait for Heaven's decree.

Mae Jonghak had spoken aloud those six characters etched in all their hearts. Jeok Cheongang distinctly remembered him smiling.

"Then I'll see you in Tianshan."

When morning came, they parted.

The Murim Alliance went west. The Imperial Army went east. And a single carriage carrying all their hopes went into the desert.

Every step of the operation had been kept secret against the possibility of spies.

By the time everyone realized Jin Taekyung's group was missing, Mae Jonghak announced that they had already joined the Imperial Army and were on the move. The Imperial Army did the same.

Both forces pushed forward with all their might, constantly spreading false information to keep Dark Heaven's eyes—wherever they might be hidden—away from the desert.

And so that, if the worst came to pass, they could serve as bait.

Now what they had feared had become reality.

What in the world happened?

Jeok Cheongang swallowed the question poised on his tongue.

He was not alone. Everyone there knew something had happened to their allies, but no one said it aloud.

What they needed now was courage and hope that wouldn't die—not anxiety, deep and sticky as a swamp.

All we can do is keep going.

The plan had not failed yet.

Though events had gone awry, they would press on toward Tianshan. Their allies would arrive late, follow their trail, and join them.

It was a faint hope. For now, believing in it was the best they could do.

"We leave. Before it gets any later."

At the sound of Jeok Cheongang's heavy voice—

Fwoosh.

The candle that had flickered precariously as it lit the room finally went out.

Once the decision was made, everyone moved in perfect order.

Only Jin Taekyung had been kept in the dark. The rest of the group had already considered every possibility and accepted the reality before them, so not one of them hesitated.

In that respect, the two days they had spent in the abandoned town had been invaluable. They had recovered from their accumulated fatigue, and the horses, worn down by the relentless forced march and unable to go farther, could be turned into provisions.

"Drain their blood and store it in gourds. Make jerky from the meat. The terrain will be too rough for a carriage from here on, and if we set them free, they'll starve to death anyway."

"D-do we really have to go this far?"

"Why? Have you grown attached to them?"

"I'd be lying if I said I hadn't. They may be beasts, but we've been together all this time. Look at their eyes. Don't you see the tears welling up? It's like they understand us."

"I see. Then starting tomorrow, you can go hungry, Hyuk."

"On second thought, my mouth's watering."

"…"

"What can they do about it? Their crime was being born beasts."

It was a sorry end for the eight sweat-blood horses that had given them everything they could. Set aside the moral question, though, and it was a perfectly reasonable decision.

Just after midnight, the moment they set foot in Tianshan for the first time, they all sensed it.

What is this place…?

It was different.

The weight of the air. The way the wind moved. Everything.

The atmosphere had changed as though they had entered a world cut off from their own. A chill ran up their spines, along with the unsettling sense that they were trapped in a prison built like a maze, with no way out.

What a vicious aura.

Jeok Cheongang's senses prickled. Even a pool full of corpses and poison would not feel this oppressive.

Then again, perhaps that was only natural.

Tianshan was the Land of Ruin that had harbored the poison called the Demonic for a thousand years.

And yet, it was also the final hill they had to cross.

They had rested. They had secured plenty of food. If they watched for dangers lurking somewhere in the thorny undergrowth, they would reach their destination before long.

We made it this far without being stopped. At least for now, that means we haven't caught their attention.

Jeok Cheongang gazed into the dark forest.

Things were going badly, but that fact alone gave them reason to hope.

And the old master, with his beloved Disciple on his back, would break before he bent.

Step.

Jeok Cheongang took his first step, putting his weight behind it.

A strong wind blew from somewhere. All around them, dense gray branches swayed, waving at the unwelcome intruders.

Chapter 1186

Everything has a beginning.

Even a white-haired old man was once a baby. Even a pebble by the roadside didn't always look the way it does now.

Everything in the world comes together according to a fixed order and changes with the passage of time.

Nothing is perfect from the start. Nothing lasts forever.

That is the law of nature, the order of the world as everyone knows it.

And yet, the group pushing through the pale mist was thinking the same thing.

Or rather, they were wondering whether everything they had always taken for granted might be little more than an illusion.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was one of them.

Damn it.

He swallowed the curse rising in his throat and looked around.

Mist coiled in every direction. Beyond it, black branches appeared and vanished in fleeting glimpses. Rugged mountains climbed without end.

Order? Laws?

Those ideas had long since been wiped from his mind.

The landscape looked as if it had been perfect in this form from the beginning and would remain unchanged ten thousand years from now. Jeok Cheongang licked his parched lips.

The sight was more chilling than a mountain of sabers and a forest of swords. Looking at it made his hundred-plus years of life, and everything he had learned in them, feel almost meaningless.

If there was any comfort, it was that he wasn't the only one who felt that way.

"Damn Tianshan."

The voice suddenly reached his ear. Jeok Cheongang silently agreed, then parted his lips.

"Don't say that. The youngsters will lose heart if they hear you."

There was only one person who would send him a Sound Transmission in a situation like this.

The Slaughter Saint's reply came at once.

"That's why I'm using Sound Transmission."

"Don't use that, either."

"Why not?"

"It wastes internal energy."

A dozen paces ahead, the Slaughter Saint turned to Jeok Cheongang with an incredulous look.

“Do I look like some Third Rate swordsman off the street? And if you’re so worried about wasting internal energy, why answer me instead of practicing what you preach?”

“This old man can afford it.”

“Why can you afford it?”

“My internal energy runs deep. Unlike some people’s.”

“…You can still crack jokes at a time like this.”

“I have to. At a time like this.”

This time, it was the Slaughter Saint’s turn to agree.

Jeok Cheongang’s subdued tone came through even in Sound Transmission, and the Slaughter Saint’s gaze grew troubled.

“Like I said earlier, this is no easy place. I thought I’d seen a fair bit of the world after traveling all across it, but… I’ve never heard of or seen anything like this.”

Unlike Jeok Cheongang, who had spent most of his life on Mount Jiuhua, the Slaughter Saint had lived as a wanderer—first as an assassin, then as a physician.

In his youth, he had traveled a thousand li[3959] to take someone’s life. In his old age, he had searched for herbs ten thousand li[3960] away to save one.

Even a young woodcutter who lived day to day cutting trees would have his own experiences and his own life. For someone who had made his mark at opposite ends of life and death, calling his experience “a fair bit” was an understatement born of extraordinary modesty.

Of course, to Jeok Cheongang, who shared the same reality, it sounded entirely sincere.

“I expected as much, but it seems even you don’t have an answer.”

“There’s no way forward, nothing we can do. We can’t even tell day from night. What can we possibly do?”

The Slaughter Saint was right.

The mist blocking their way wasn’t confined to the ground.

Dark clouds hung overhead.

At first, they had thought the enormous black mass was passing through. Instead, it had covered the sky.

It had swallowed the moon and stars that had faintly lit the way above them at first. It wouldn’t allow even a single ray of sunlight through.

[3959] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi). A thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi); ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,110 mi).

[3960] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi). A thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi); ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,110 mi).

As though it meant to frighten the rude intruders who had come without its permission.

“Do you think any of this is a coincidence?”

“A coincidence?”

Jeok Cheongang let out a hollow laugh before he knew it.

“The old me would certainly have thought so. Before I met a certain impudent brat who’s riding on his master’s back while the old man works himself to the bone at his age.”

Jeok Cheongang gazed at the face of the “impudent brat” resting on one of his shoulders.

His Disciple had appeared out of nowhere one day and turned the life of an old, sick man upside down.

Now he was changing not just one man’s life, but everyone’s world.

“There are no more coincidences for us. Everything that happens from here on is intended, inevitable. And maybe…”

Maybe it was fate, decided from the very beginning.

Jeok Cheongang quietly swallowed the words he had been about to add.

It wasn’t that he didn’t believe in fate.

If all of this was fate, it was far too cruel to Jin Taekyung. Worse, Jeok Cheongang was afraid of how this story might end.

“Maybe what?”

“No, nothing. Let’s leave it. What matters more is the situation we’re in.”

Jeok Cheongang’s words and behavior were plainly unnatural, but the Slaughter Saint didn’t press him.

He was a little disappointed, but everyone had worries of their own. And the Jeok Cheongang he had come to know was far more thoughtful and sensitive than people gave him credit for.

Especially where Jin Taekyung was concerned.

Then again, I’m hardly in a position to judge him for that.

The Slaughter Saint’s gaze shifted past Jeok Cheongang’s shoulder.

The younger members of the group were racing over the rugged terrain, breathing hard. Behind them, Great Sir and the Bow Saint brought up the rear, their faces calm.

His gaze rested on them for only a moment. Then he spoke as if nothing had happened.

This time, in his own voice rather than through Sound Transmission.

“We should take a short break.”

His voice carried through the mist, which had grown denser still.

The Slaughter Saint had made the right call.

The moment they stopped, Hyuk Mujin began retching. Instead of patting him on the back, Gung Gibang pulled out some jerky.

"…You traitor. Is that jerky really so good?"

Ju Hwaran eventually helped Hyuk Mujin stop retching. Gung Gibang answered his accusation without hesitation.

"Of course."

"…"

"Seriously, this stuff is incredible. Is it because it came from sweat-blood horses? The flavor's remarkably consistent."

"…"

"Don't glare at me. Just eat. You'll need your strength. Or you could sit down and circulate your qi like that fellow."

Hyuk Mujin glanced between Song Ilseom, who was already sitting cross-legged, and Gung Gibang, who was still tearing into his jerky. Then his expression hardened as he made up his mind.

"Give me a piece. I want to see what's so good about it that you're eating like a beggar who hasn't had a meal in three days."

When they had first met, there had been a considerable gap between them in both standing and martial prowess. But they had traveled together long enough to become all but friends.

Gung Gibang grinned, showing his yellow teeth.

"Excellent decision. Oh, Young Lady Ju, would you like some, too?"

"No, thank you. I think I'd better circulate my qi for a while."

Replenishing one's strength and refining one's internal energy were both good choices.

Climbing mountains—especially rugged ones at this altitude—was exhausting in a way that running across flat ground wasn't.

Besides, even they, whose martial arts were far less advanced than those of the masters traveling with them, could feel the heavy air hanging over all of Tianshan and the strange phenomena that defied explanation.

"Damn it. I can't even remember the last time I felt warm sunlight."

Hyuk Mujin answered Gung Gibang with his mouth stuffed full of jerky.

"We got some in the desert."

"How was that warm sunlight? I was scared to go out during the day in case I burned to death. Though by the time we were halfway across, I did start to miss it."

“Fair enough. That weather was a real pain in the ass.”

In truth, “a real pain in the ass” didn’t begin to cover it.

What kind of desert had no cacti or bugs, yet got alternating hailstorms and downpours for more than half a month?

But that was the world now.

And to survive in a changed world, they had to change, too.

“I’m dying here. How many peaks have we climbed already?”

“Five.”

“Already? That’s more than I thought.”

“Not when you consider how hard we’ve been running. And we don’t know how much farther we have to go.”

The Tianshan Mountains were wide.

No, “wide” didn’t do them justice. They were vast.

The range stretched for more than a thousand li[3961] and covered a full third of Xinjiang.

And that wasn’t all. It was a Sacred Land where only a select few of the old Demonic Cult’s members had been allowed to enter—and a Land of Ruin where outsiders were certain to die.

They still had no idea which of its hundreds of peaks held the Cult’s headquarters.

“Terrible.”

“Terrible.”

“At least nothing’s happened yet. That should mean we haven’t been spotted.”

“If the Captain heard you say that, he’d smack you one.”

“Why?”

“He hates that sort of talk. Says it’s bad luck. Then he starts on about ‘cli’ or ‘guli’ or something that sounds like copper. I never know what he means.”

“Honestly, I can never figure him out.”

“Tell me about it.”

The two muttered almost to themselves, then lay on their backs and stared blankly at the sky.

Or rather, at the dark clouds covering every inch of it.

“How long exactly have we been here?”

“More than a day, less than two.”

“Are you sure?”

“I’m sure.”

“Impressive, when we can’t even tell night from day.”

[3961] In this Chinese setting, one li is about 500 m (0.311 mi). A thousand li is about 500 km (311 mi); ten thousand li is about 5,000 km (3,110 mi).

Hyuk Mujin answered firmly.

“Because the Captain still hasn’t woken up.”

“Oh, right. He’s supposed to wake up within two days at the latest.”

“Exactly. So it definitely hasn’t been two days yet.”

Gung Gibang studied him for a moment, then gave a quiet laugh.

“What?”

“It’s just… How do I put this? You really are something.”

“What do you mean?”

“Almost everything seems to revolve around Jin Taekyung.”

“I don’t know. It’s just so natural to me.”

“Don’t get me wrong. I’m not saying it’s strange, or that I don’t understand. I’m saying it because I know exactly how it feels.”

The smile on Gung Gibang’s lips faded.

“That’s what a martial family is. You may not share blood, but sometimes the bond runs deeper than blood.”

Gung Gibang fell into memories for a moment, and Hyuk Mujin went quiet.

It felt as though a wound long held closed had finally split open.

The Jin Family of Taiyuan. The Beggars’ Sect.

Their martial families, their other homes—and the names of two enormous stones weighing down their hearts.

What had happened to the people who had marched west with their banners held high?

If they were still alive, would they ever meet again?

They could trade silly remarks and force smiles, but reality was cold enough to make them shudder.

And it moved so quickly that they had no time to fight off the chill before it seeped into their bones.

Shhhhhhhh.

A sudden sense of wrongness.

Hyuk Mujin’s eyes widened. In them, the mist writhed as though it were alive.

Chapter 1187

A snake.

That was the first word that came to everyone's mind when they saw the mist writhing toward them.

Gloomy and dark, it crept closer like a huge predator that had spotted its prey. Their legs had gone stiff as stone and would hardly lift from the ground.

Something beyond what they could see was stirring a primal fear in them.

And the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, was one of the few people who could recognize the true nature of the power within that mist before anyone else—and understand it clearly.

This is…!

There was no doubt.

Demonic qi.

No—magical power, as it was now also called. That abyssal energy flowed through his five senses, binding his body and mind.

Terrifyingly fast. Insidiously.

Yet even as fear welled up inside him, Jeok Cheongang felt an intense pull he couldn't explain.

It was a strange feeling. Like the warm embrace of a mother he could no longer remember. If he gave himself over to the mist, everything would be easier.

Surely a peaceful paradise awaited him in that hazy world, free of hardship and anguish—

Crunch!

Pain stung his tongue, and blood filled his mouth.

Jeok Cheongang had bitten down in the nick of time. His senses clear again, he spat out the blood and roared.

"Hah!"

His azure dragon's roar, driven by mighty internal energy, shook the air in every direction.

He wasn't the only one to let out a cry like a beast's roar.

The Bow Saint and the Slaughter Saint had reacted at the same instant. The two superhumans groaned as they watched the mist falter, if only briefly.

Dark arts.

An immensely powerful, sinister force unlike anything they had ever seen was consuming the space around them.

No—perhaps all of Tianshan.

But they faced an even greater problem.

"Ah…"

"Ahhh…"

Their companions stared dreamily ahead, voices vacant. Their hands reached through empty air as their feet carried them slowly toward the mist.

Not one of them was spared. Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin were closest to it, but even Ju Hwaran and Song Ilseom, farther away, were moving toward it.

They looked like people who had lost their souls. Sensing the danger, the three veteran masters shot toward them without hesitation.

And just as they reached out, their hands moving like streaks of light—

Whoosh!

A sharp whistle cut through the air. Space warped.

The mist had curled into the razor-sharp claw of a giant beast. Jeok Cheongang saw the darkness steeped within it reflected in his reddish eyes.

"How dare you!"

Fwoosh—BOOM!

Flames burst from his Flame Divine Palm with his furious cry, shattering the claw of magical power and heating the air. The infernal blaze would not let it come an inch closer.[3962]

But he soon realized the brief attack had been deliberate.

Shhhhhhh.

Pale steam billowed up. Jeok Cheongang's eyes widened.

He couldn't see them.

Gung Gibang's threadbare collar had been within reach. Hyuk Mujin's head had been right there, making Jeok Cheongang want to smack it on sight.

No.

They're gone.

That was the only way to put it. He had seen their bodies disappear into the mist, as though erased from the world.

What in the…

Jeok Cheongang swallowed the groan rising in his throat and looked around. Then he realized something else.

Gung Gibang and Hyuk Mujin weren't the only ones who had vanished.

"…Hah."

He let out the breath he had been holding.

When had it happened? Had it begun with that strange sense of déjà vu?

He didn't know. The scenery before him looked unchanged, but everything else was different.

[3962] One chi, a traditional Korean measure of length, is 3.03 cm (1.19 in).

No one was there. No one.

Even the Bow Saint and the Slaughter Saint, who had stood scarcely thirty feet away, were nowhere to be seen. He could sense neither their presence nor a trace of their qi.

An illusion technique? Or a Mystic Gate Formation?

Dark arts he had heard of in rumors, and others he had faced himself on the battlefields of the Great Faction War, flashed through his mind. None gave him an answer.

Even Jeok Cheongang, who had lived for more than a century and dominated an era, had never encountered dark arts like these.

This is something else entirely.

Even the great fiends of the previous generation, notorious under names like the Illusion Fiend and Guiguzi, had never managed anything like it.

More precisely, Jeok Cheongang's formidable martial prowess had never allowed them to.

Even the strongest dark arts had their limits.

The Illusion Fiend, the Demonic Cult's greatest master of illusion, had had both eyes gouged out. Guiguzi, who had slaughtered hundreds of orthodox Murim warriors with his intricate Mystic Gate Formation, had melted into a pool of blood.

Both at the hands of one man: the Fire King, Jeok Cheongang.

But…

I've never seen or heard of a formation like this.

Jeok Cheongang stretched his senses farther than ever before. The longer he searched, the more certain he became.

No matter how bizarre the dark arts, there should be a flow of energy and a core at its center. In this strange space, he could find neither.

Only the dark mist approaching with the uniquely sticky, unpleasant energy of demonic qi—and someone's steady breathing against his back.

"Sleeping through all this. You've got it easy, you know."

A faint smile touched his lips despite his grumbling. He glanced at the Disciple who would have protested bitterly if he were awake, then muttered as though making a promise to himself.

"Don't worry. Whatever happens, I won't let a single hair on you come to harm…"

His voice trailed off.

After a moment's silence, he added with a sigh, "Just bear with it. Losing one hair won't kill you."

His Disciple offered no answer. Jeok Cheongang fixed his fiercely shining eyes on the dense mist.

"What are you waiting for? Crawl the hell out here!"

The beings beyond the pale veil answered his call.

Grrrr.

The mist rolled in waves. At last, countless eyes gleamed within it.

Jeok Cheongang drew a slow breath.

“Come in a whole pack, have you?”

Heat shimmered around him as Extreme Yang energy spread through his limbs and every part of his body. He raised both fists, wrapped in fierce flames, toward the monsters that did not belong in this world.

“Come.”

The long night had begun.

The mist was too thick to see an inch ahead.[3963] Countless shadows surged through it.

At the center of it all, flames burned ever more fiercely.

Boom!

One palm strike.

No more, no less. The motion was devastating in its efficiency. In its wake lay only heat enough to melt rock—and death.

Thud!

A huge body that could not be called human sank to its knees.

The three red eyes in its single head were still fixed on their prey, but the chest melted away without a trace proved which of them had been the hunter.

Grrk.

Light drained swiftly from its eyes. Before the monster had breathed its last, the hunter had already turned to set other living things ablaze.

Crunch!

He smashed, burst, and crushed without pause.

Hands, feet, legs, knees, elbows—sometimes even his forehead. Every part of him was a weapon, and every blow meant something’s death.

Neither the five-foot-tall monsters[3964] nor the three-headed, six-armed ones could break through the blazing wall of fire.

Claws sharper than scythes and rusty blades in place of arms struck relentlessly at his limbs. Jeok Cheongang’s body and mind never faltered.

It was like the day Mount Jiuhua had been engulfed in flames, decades ago.

No. He was stronger and colder now than he had been then—beyond comparison.

[3963] One chi, a traditional Korean measure of length, is 3.03 cm (1.19 in).

[3964] Five cheok is about 1.52 m (5 ft). One cheok, a traditional Korean measure of length, is 30.3 cm (11.9 in).

The thousand members of the Demonic Cult who had drawn the old monster known as the Fire King out of Mount Jiuhua had at least looked human. These were cursed beings that should never have appeared in the human world.

Kyarruk!

Kraaaaah!

They carried a madness and killing intent unlike anything he had felt before. They had clearly lost their reason long ago and moved only at their master's command. Still, they charged without cease—

RrrrCRUNCH!

—and died without respite.

Splaaat!

Blood sprayed high into the air. With a single sweep of his hand, as if brushing away insects, Jeok Cheongang sent hundreds of shreds of flesh flying in every direction.

"Is that all?"

In the sudden gap left by death, he swept his gaze around him and muttered, "Did you think that would be enough to bring this old man down?"

The words of his Master came to mind. Time had blurred even the man's face.

Cheongang, the world is vast, and there are many strong people.

The world beyond Mount Jiuhua had been as vast as his Master had said.

The Heavenly Demon, who had swallowed half the world, and the great fiends who followed him were strong. So were the Daoists[3965] and the damned monks who held the Central Plains.

But that wasn't all his Master had said.

But you could become one of the strongest among them.

As always, his Master had been right.

And the young life he carried on his back made him stronger still.

"If you won't come to me, I'll come to you."

Hiss.

Heat rose where he planted his foot.

Had even these mindless monsters retained their instincts? Faced with the overwhelming difference in strength, they had halted their attack.

Jeok Cheongang started toward them.

Or rather, he meant to.

Until a voice he could never forget pierced his ear.

"You haven't changed."

Jeok Cheongang froze.

[3965] Daoists are practitioners of Daoism, a Chinese religious and philosophical tradition.

The fierce light in his eyes faded like a lamp caught by the wind. Reflected in them was the face of someone who could not be here—and should not be.

Chapter 1188

It was as if time had stopped.

The foul odors and reek of blood that had filled the air faded, and the monsters' roars became faint echoes. But Jeok Cheongang noticed none of the changes around him.

No—he couldn't.

All his senses were fixed on a single person.

Squish.

Unhurried footsteps approached through a pool of blood.

The countless monsters had stopped moving and parted to either side. Between them, someone came into view, filling Jeok Cheongang's vision.

The sight chilled his heart so deeply it hurt.

"…You."

The voice that slipped between his bloodless lips was more than a sound. It was a groan he couldn't hold back, a scream he had barely managed to suppress.

"Have you been well?"

A voice he had never forgotten. A face that had grown a little unfamiliar.

The name of the man he was seeing again after well over ten years spilled from Jeok Cheongang's lips with a cold breath.

"Cheon-ah,[3966] how are you—?"

The man, Jangcheon, smiled faintly at his former Master.

"It's been a long time since anyone called me that."

Each quiet word burrowed into Jeok Cheongang's ears, raked through his lungs, and pierced his heart.

"I was worried you might not recognize me."

As if that were possible.

Even if a hundred years had passed instead of ten, Jeok Cheongang would have recognized him. Then or now, however much had changed, Jangcheon was someone he could never forget for as long as he lived.

"But I needn't have worried. You, of all people, would never forget me, Master. I nearly failed to recognize you, though, unworthy Disciple that I am."

Since the day they had parted in a dark back alley, the Disciple had aged a little, while his Master had grown much younger.

But it wasn't only Jeok Cheongang's appearance that had changed when he Returned to Youth, leaving him looking like a middle-aged man.

Everything had changed.

[3966] *-ah* is a familiar Korean form of address added to a name that ends in a consonant.

Every last thing.

And among those changes was a truth no one could undo.

“You… weren’t you already dead?”

It had been a day of heavy snowfall, or so Jeok Cheongang had heard.

Somewhere on an unnamed mountainside near Jeongyang in Shanxi Province, Jangcheon had died before several witnesses. Miserably, wretchedly, as though he were being judged for the many atrocities he had committed.

But then—

How could—

“Dead? Me?”

His eyes widened for a moment, then curved with a laugh.

“Ha. Did you think I was the kind of bastard who’d die that easily?”

“No. I heard, quite clearly—”

“Yes, you heard. You didn’t see it for yourself.”

Jeok Cheongang’s gaze wavered at the calm reply.

It was true.

By the time he had asked around and found the place, only a few traces of the fierce battle remained. Jangcheon’s body was nowhere to be found. No one knew exactly why, and Jeok Cheongang hadn’t wanted to know.

Jeok Cheongang had only thought that the heavy snow said to have continued for nearly seven days and nights, along with the mountain beasts, might have erased Jangcheon’s last traces from the earth.

That was all.

He had left a bottle of liquor and a few drops of tears there, then returned to his own life.

That was what had happened.

“…You were alive all this time?”

“I nearly died. At the hands of that brat you’re looking after like a sacred ancestral tablet.”

Jangcheon’s pale, misty gaze settled on Jin Taekyung’s face over Jeok Cheongang’s shoulder.

“I can feel a familiar power in him. The qi of our sect, the Fire Gate Clan. Once, only you and I carried it.”

Jeok Cheongang said nothing. Jangcheon took another slow step.

Squish.

“I’ve heard no end of it. Apparently, I have a Junior Brother I never knew about.”

“You’re wrong. About all of it.”

Jeok Cheongang forced the words through clenched teeth.

"This boy is not your Junior Brother, and you are no Disciple of mine."

"Why not?"

"Because you were cast out. You died committing unforgivable atrocities. That is the only truth."

Crack.

His lips split, and blood filled his mouth.

But the sight before him—which had to be an illusion—didn't change. Neither the shadowed face of his former Disciple nor the voice that kept reaching his ears.

"But Master, look. I'm still alive, aren't I?"

"Don't call me that!"

Even at Jeok Cheongang's thunderous shout, Jangcheon kept coming. He looked at him with eyes full of regret.

"I knew what you must think of me, Master."

"Shut your mouth!"

"After I came back from the brink of death, I spent a great deal of time thinking about everything that had happened. Every day felt like ten years."

Squish.

The pool of blood rippled beneath his advancing steps.

Behind him, the monsters stood still as though they had agreed not to move. As Jangcheon drew closer, Jeok Cheongang could sense no danger or killing intent from him.

But—

That can't be. It's all an illusion. I'm hearing things.

Jeok Cheongang clenched his fists. The qi within him surged as though it had sensed its master's turmoil, threatening to slip beyond his control. He subdued it and began to draw it up again.

Then Jangcheon said something he had never expected to hear.

"I was wrong. This unworthy Disciple was wrong about everything."

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang's eyes trembled. Unlike his body, which had regained its youth, they still held the weight of all his years.

"Please forgive me. No—Master, punish this wretched man yourself."

No. That couldn't be.

He must not fall for lies conjured by dark arts.

And yet—

The Extreme Yang energy gathering in his clenched fists wavered like a candle in the wind, then went out.

Just as it had on the day when, despite possessing martial arts powerful enough to look down on the world, he could do nothing but watch his Disciple walk away.

“I won’t make excuses. Whatever punishment you give me, I’ll bear it all.”

The words he had wanted so badly to hear.

“I betrayed your trust, disgraced our sect, and killed innocent people. I committed sins I can never wash away.”

The scene he had imagined countless times.

“So please, kill me.”

“…Enough.”

“Kill me. With the very hands that took me in more than twenty years ago.”

“Enough. Stop.”

Jeok Cheongang couldn’t breathe. His heart ached as though an unseen hand were squeezing it.

Everything he was seeing and hearing had to be nothing but an illusion.

It had to be.

Yet the wound deep inside him, the one he had thought long since closed, was tearing open again.

“Master.”

Jeok Cheongang did not answer.

He only stared blankly at his old Disciple as his vision grew hazy. Old, worn memories overlaid the sight.

“If I can’t take you as my Master… I’ll kill myself.”

Even after more than twenty years, he remembered clearly.

“No, kill me now. With the very hands that saved me.”

The desperate look in the boy’s eyes.

“Might Makes Right. Didn’t you teach me that, Master? That’s what Murim is—no, what the world is. The weak should die at the hands of the strong.”

The murderer’s smile he could never forget.

“Kill me. It’s the only way to stop me.”

And the feeble old man who, in the end, had failed to stop him.

Even after he had gone out into the world to correct that mistake, he had lingered for a long time at the very spot where wild beasts and snow-laden winds had passed.

“Old man, has something happened?”

It was the place where the man who had lived as Jangcheon had fallen under the name Jopil.

A traveler, finding it strange that Jeok Cheongang still stood there late into the night, motionless as a stone monument, had asked him what was wrong. Jeok Cheongang had answered that his only blood relative had died there.

The man had been foolish and useless beyond words, but he had come hoping to at least recover the body.

And in that moment, he had realized that even after nearly ten years, he still wasn't ready.

"Master."

The clear voice scattered the layers of memory.

Tears streamed down Jeok Cheongang's face like water through a broken dam. Through them, he saw the Disciple he had wanted so badly to meet again.

"Cheon-ah.[3967]"

"Yes. Your Disciple is listening, Master. I'm here with you."

Squish.

One step.

Squish.

Another step.

Squish.

They were close enough to feel each other's breath.

Jeok Cheongang beckoned to the Disciple he had finally met again. Jangcheon took the last step toward his Master's small embrace.

With him came a streak of light prepared, from the very beginning, for this moment alone.

Thnk.

Pain hotter than any Scorching Yang Qi.

Blood burst forth at the same instant, as though to prove this was real.

Shhk! Patter, patter!

Fresh blood spattered the ground. Across a handspan of empty space, their gazes met.

One deeply sunken. The other wide with disbelief.

In the brief silence, Jangcheon's lips parted.

"…How?"

At Jangcheon's question, his agitation impossible to hide, Jeok Cheongang smiled sadly.

"I wanted to be fooled for a moment. I wasn't fooled."

He tightened his grip on the blade he had caught at the last instant.

Crreeeak.

It hurt.

Every time the dagger embedded in his palm twisted, a dizzying pain spread through his body.

But it didn't matter. This was nothing compared to the mind demon that had tormented him moments before.

[3967] *-ah* is a familiar Korean form of address added to a name that ends in a consonant.

“What’s your name?”

It had been more than twenty years ago.

He had met a boy who endured kicks raining down on his whole body and still managed to shove a dirt-covered bun into his mouth.

“…I don’t know.”

Jeok Cheongang had seen his younger self in the boy: a fierce little child who had once wandered the world begging for food, without even knowing his own name.

Perhaps that was why the old man’s heart had acted on a whim.

“Jangcheon. From now on, your name is Jangcheon.”

The Master had given him a name and a new life. The Disciple had thrown them both away and left.

The wound that departure had carved deep in Jeok Cheongang’s heart had become a scar that would never fade.

But…

“I think I can let you go now.”

Yes. At last.

With those words Jangcheon would never hear, Jeok Cheongang threw a single punch.

Kwaaaaaah!

Fierce flames consumed Jangcheon—or rather, whatever had taken on his likeness—and swept across the mountainside.

Chapter 1189

“Grrrraaaaaah!”

It wasn’t a scream a human could make—or even a sound any living creature could produce.

It was all that remained to a monster that had already died once and forgotten pain: a warning bell announcing that his corrupted soul had burned away, the final cry of his second death.

Fwooooooom!

The hellfire of the Flame-Extinguishing Divine Fist swept wildly through the space.

Then came a blinding flash, followed by an even louder roar.

RrrrRUMBLE!

The ground shook. Embers and ash churned together and scattered in every direction.

Beyond them, a shadow slowly crumpled.

Jangcheon.

No—one of the monsters wearing Jangcheon’s likeness.

Black Ghost.

Jeok Cheongang recognized it at once.

A monster given new life using the body and soul of the dead.

Neither dead nor alive, Black Ghosts were among the strangest and most powerful of the countless monsters under the Lord of Heaven.

Yes, this was surely—

Magic, after all.

A space where even the wind brushing his skin felt alien. Phenomena too intricate and bizarre to be explained by a mere formation.

The suspicion he had harbored became certainty. Jeok Cheongang felt the flow of qi around the area begin to churn.

And he sensed the cause of the change, too.

Shhhhh.

A sudden cold wind pressed down on the heat haze distorting the space and settled the drifting embers and ash.

It wasn’t an ordinary wind. It was a wave of qi announcing the arrival of something else.

“So, you’ve come.”

Jeok Cheongang looked steadily at the new intruders.

East, west, south, and north.

Four shadows had appeared around him, each gazing his way.

Different faces, yet somehow alike.

“Master.”

Four voices rang out as one.

There was Jangcheon as a dirt-covered child, just as he’d looked the day they first met. Jangcheon as a boy, pleading to be accepted as a Disciple. Jangcheon as a young man, and Jangcheon as he’d looked on the day he left.

All frozen in forms from a day that could never be taken back.

“Master. I’ve come. Cheon-ah is here.”

The four Jangcheons spoke together and stepped forward. At the same time, the countless monsters encircling the area tightened their ring.

A net over heaven and earth, drawn tight for one man alone.

Yet even amid the monsters’ killing intent, Jeok Cheongang spoke calmly.

“How strange. Four more Disciples I never knew I had.”

“Master. How could you forget me?”

The voice rang out from every direction, as if all four shared a single body. Jeok Cheongang gave a bitter smile.

“I haven’t forgotten. I’ve only decided to keep you in my memories.”

He wasn’t speaking to the monsters wearing the illusion. He was speaking to his old Disciple, who wasn’t there.

It didn’t matter if his words reached no one. Only now did he know for certain, and if he didn’t say it now, he might never get the chance.

Even if the living Jangcheon had appeared before him, his choice would have been the same.

“I was a poor Master, and you were a poor Disciple. But let’s leave the wrongs we did each other for some distant day when we meet again.”

Spilled water couldn’t be gathered up, and time that had passed couldn’t be turned back.

What mattered was now. And Jeok Cheongang still had someone precious to protect.

“So, Cheon-ah.”

As he had long ago, Jeok Cheongang spoke his old Disciple’s name gently, letting it leave his lips.

His eyes moved from one face to the next, taking in the features still etched vividly in his memory. He felt the warmth and breath of someone on his back.

He felt that he was alive, and resolved to stay that way.

“I expel you from the sect.”

In that instant—

Whoosh!

A flash erupted in the dark mist.

No. It was a flame burning as bright as light—a giant of fire, finally risen to his feet.

Fwooooooom!

The heat of the Flamefire Path distorted the space.

One step. Nearly a hundred yards vanished, and the monsters' wide eyes rushed closer.

Crunch!

No more words or thoughts were needed.

The Fire King, Jeok Cheongang, crushed everything before him.

Enemies surged in from every direction, but he saw and felt everything happening around him.

With his eyes, his ears, and sometimes with a sixth sense beyond the other five.

"Grrrraah!"

A group of monsters charged at him, each with eight arms and three heads.

They looked like asuras[3968] from legend. Their many arms—impossible now to tell whether they belonged to humans or beasts—whipped wildly, raining blows down on Jeok Cheongang's head.

Or, more precisely, on the spot where he had been.

Crack-crack-crack!

Their attacks cut through empty air and carved up the ground. Then a voice pierced the monsters' ears.

Quiet, yet hot as fire—and somehow colder than ice.

"How many hearts do you have?"

That was the last thing they heard.

Fwoosh—SPLAT!

Even as their consciousness faded, the monsters didn't know when or how they had died.

They didn't know Jeok Cheongang had launched himself off the ground, extended his Palm Force, and slashed downward with it. Nor did they know that the horrific heat within it had burned not only their hearts, but every organ in their bodies.

But the four pairs of eyes watching Jeok Cheongang did know.

They had been waiting for this moment from the start. As if on cue, they moved together without a hair's breadth of error.

ShhhhK!

A low, faint whistle slipped into his senses, keen as a blade and chilling enough to raise goose bumps.

[3968] Asuras are powerful, often warlike beings in Hindu and Buddhist traditions.

Jeok Cheongang, who had just melted dozens of monsters in an instant, immediately sensed the ominous energy closing in on him.

He sensed that there was more than one.

But their speed—and the power they carried—exceeded anything he'd expected.

"…!"

In that slowed instant, Jeok Cheongang sensed four streaks of Force flying at him from his blind spots.

He twisted with all his might, moving by instinct more than reason.

Shhk!

Blood sprayed with a cool slicing sound.

Not the monsters' green blood, with its foul stench and poisonous fumes, but the red blood of a living human.

Even through the sting of pain, Jeok Cheongang regained his balance at the last possible moment and landed with a satisfied smile.

What a relief.

His own flesh had been cut, but Jin Taekyung hadn't so much as been scratched.

The smile brought on by that relief didn't last long.

His wound wasn't serious. The battle, however, was clearly going against him.

A Master fighting to protect his Disciple, against countless monsters charging without fear of death.

And the greatest problem of all: the four Black Ghosts, carefully measuring their distance and looking for an opening even now.

Strong. Stronger than I expected.

They seemed at least a step above the other Black Ghosts he had faced—perhaps nearly two.

He had no way of knowing whether that was because of the Magic surrounding the area or because these four were particularly powerful Black Ghosts. But one thing was certain.

This will be a tough fight.

In truth, even that didn't begin to describe it.

Their individual strength was formidable, but the four Supreme Peak masters moved like one organism, sharing their thoughts. Even Jeok Cheongang couldn't afford to underestimate them.

That would have been true even if they were living humans. But these monsters felt neither emotion nor pain.

And everything was going in their favor.

Even now.

"Grrrraaaah!"

The monsters roared and charged again, while the Black Ghosts vanished among them. Jeok Cheongang understood their intentions at once.

They're taking turns wearing me down…!

To break a huge rock quickly, you needed a sharp chisel and a heavy hammer. Given enough time, though, even the occasional shower would do.

Drop by drop, the water struck the hard surface of the rock until cracks began to form.

But the monsters surging endlessly under the Black Ghosts' command were neither light raindrops nor a passing shower.

They were waves.

Raging waves, driven by the force to smash through any reef and a blind madness that sent them hurling their lives away without hesitation.

But Jeok Cheongang wasn't a rock that would stand still and wait to be worn down.

I'll end this at once.

His nature was fire. He had raised a greater flame than anyone under heaven, and so he was the Fire King.

Crack.

Jeok Cheongang clenched his teeth.

His eyes glowed red, piercing the dark mist. Space warped along the heat haze rising in strands from his entire body.

Fwoooosh.

Energy like molten lava surged through his limbs and every part of his body. A breath like steam escaped between his slowly parting lips.

"I'll kill every last one of you."

If they were rocks, he would melt them. If they were waves, he would make them evaporate.

Even if he himself turned to ash, even if everything burned away, the Fire Gate Clan's flame would not go out.

No—a blaze greater than his own would rise from it.

"Come!"

The giant's roar shook the air in every direction as he completed his preparations.

"Whoa, you startled me. My ears are going to burst."

"…!"

Jeok Cheongang barely managed to rein in the internal energy that had nearly surged back against him.

Chapter 1190

Silence fell for a moment.

The monsters blinked their glowing eyes at the unexpected turn of events. So did the four Black Ghosts who were supposed to be commanding them.

In that brief stillness, Jeok Cheongang slowly turned his head. Over his shoulder, he found a pair of eyes staring blankly at him.

“What is it, you bastard?”

Unlike his Master, who had barely managed to squeeze out the words, the Disciple answered without hesitation.

“It’s me.”

“Not that.”

“What, then?”

“When did you wake up? No—how?”

“I just woke up.”

“…I mean, how?”

Jeok Cheongang wondered if he was seeing things.

Hadn’t the Slaughter Saint—and the Divine Physician himself—insisted that the effects wouldn’t fully wear off for at least another half a day?

Could this be a hallucination caused by Magic or something?

Just as that rather plausible suspicion began to grow, a familiar voice reached his ears again.

“What kind of question is that? I woke up because I woke up.”

The expression and tone were unmistakably annoyed.

With much of his suspicion fading, Jeok Cheongang asked, “Proof?”

“What proof? Do you wake up every morning thinking, ‘Wow, that’s crazy. How on earth did I wake up today?‘ Well, considering your age, maybe you do.”

“…!”

You could imitate the outside, but what was inside never changed.

Jeok Cheongang’s fists began to itch, as though he’d been reunited with his long-lost soulmate. At last, he let go of every doubt.

“So it really is you!”

“Yes, it’s me. So could you lower your voice a little? I’ve been listening to you this whole time, and I think my eardrums are a little busted.”

“I should’ve known better than to believe a word that quack said—wait. What do you mean, you’ve been listening this whole time?”

“Exactly what it sounds like.”

“You were awake? Since when?”

“When you said, ‘How many hearts do you have?‘ Judging by that line alone, you sounded like the Heavenly Demon.”

At that answer, Jeok Cheongang let out a quiet sigh of relief.

Thank goodness.

If Jin Taekyung had regained consciousness a little earlier, he would have seen what happened before. He would have been hurt to learn that his Master still hadn’t been able to put that burden down.

Then a thought struck Jeok Cheongang.

“…If you were already awake, why did you stay quiet?”

“At first, I thought it was a dream.”

Jin Taekyung answered without a hint of shame, then added, “But it was comfortable, so I stayed put a little longer.”

“Heh.”

Jeok Cheongang smiled warmly at his Disciple’s honesty.

“Still comfortable?”

“Of course.”

“How strange. I’m not comfortable.”

“One thing I’ve learned from all my years of living is that life isn’t always comfortable.”

“And do you plan to keep living?”

“Isn’t that obvious?”

“Then how about you get down already?”

“My back’s nice and warm from your Scorching Yang Qi, so could I stay up here another seven or eight minutes?”

“Of course. Anything’s possible.”

The smile vanished from Jeok Cheongang’s lips.

“You’ll just be half dead.”

“Ah. I’d rather not.”

With a deep sigh, Jin Taekyung hopped down to the ground.

He didn’t have to focus, put any strength into it, or draw on his internal energy. The moment he thought of moving, the thick iron chains binding Master and Disciple together burst apart like a spiderweb crushed beneath a boulder.

Crack-crack-crack!

The act was as simple as breathing. Its consequences were anything but.

Shhhhing—SPLAT!

A harsh metallic shriek. A blurred streak cutting through the air. Then the dreadful sound of torn flesh and blood gushing up like a fountain.

A group of monsters caught by the chains as they flew apart crumpled like straw. Four glowing gazes flashed around them.

"—Jin. Taekyung."

The voices echoed through the space, layered over one another.

Jin Taekyung studied the Black Ghosts' faces and shrugged.

"Yeah, it's your hyung[3969]."

"—The chosen one."

"—Target confirmed."

"—Carry out the order. As that person wills."

"Pick one of you to do the talking. You all look so alike I can barely tell you apart as it is."

His tone and expression were calm. But White Flame, the spear now in his hand, gleamed unmistakably through the mist.

"Still, there's something familiar about those mugs. I feel like I've seen them somewhere."

Jeok Cheongang faltered at the unexpected response, then swallowed a bitter smile.

Perhaps it was only natural that Jin Taekyung didn't recognize those faces. To him, they were just one among countless villains he'd glimpsed for a fleeting instant.

It's probably better if he doesn't remember.

A Master should always be a pillar for his Disciple, someone he could lean on.

That was why Jeok Cheongang didn't want him to know. He couldn't let him see how rotten he was inside, beneath a surface that looked so solid.

Yes. This is enough.

Suppressing the words circling in his heart, Jeok Cheongang spoke in a deliberately calm tone.

"Well, even if you have seen them, what would that change?"

"Fair enough."

Bzzzz.

At Jin Taekyung's answer, the silver spearhead trembled.

A tremendous energy began to pulse at last, and dark blue flames rose and billowed.

"Be careful. These things are different from the ones we've faced so far."

"I know."

"You do?"

"Yeah. I've been to places like this so many times I'm sick of them."

[3969] *Hyung* is a Korean term a man uses for an older brother or an older male acquaintance.

Jin Taekyung drew a deep breath. The air was unpleasantly damp and foul-smelling.

He knew this place.

More precisely, he could feel its true nature against every inch of his skin.

Even if those translucent letters hadn't appeared in midair, that fact wouldn't have changed.

> **System** - You have entered the restricted area **Tianshan Mountains**. - You have entered the mutated Gate **Forest of Death-I**. - The abilities of all enemies within this restricted area and Gate have been greatly increased. - All manner of evil Magic and the energy of death are consuming the area. Do not let your guard down. - You have not yet met the Gate-clearing conditions.

A Gate. A passage through which demons marched into another world—and a land of death that had become their prison.

A graveyard that had swallowed countless Hunters.

Whoosh.

The flames wrapping around the spearhead surged higher.

They burned like a campfire sheltering souls that had died in the cold, and like a gravekeeper's torch driving off the unclean things wandering this vast cemetery.

Higher. Fiercer.

Until their dark blue light filled his Master's wide eyes.

Jeok Cheongang drew a sharp breath.

The flames before him were that vast, that hot—

And that bright.

They shone with a different light from his Master's, yet carried an even warmer power.

"…!"

Jin Taekyung gave his wide-eyed Master a faint smile.

"I told you. A lot's happened."

"You…"

What was Jeok Cheongang supposed to say?

He didn't spend long wondering. After a brief moment at a loss for words, he clenched his fists.

"Let's go."

No answer or question followed that brief command.

The moment the words left his lips, Master and Disciple were already surging toward their enemies, setting the air ablaze.

No.

The two Fire Kings.

Rrrrrumble!

Their flames merged into hellfire nothing could extinguish and tore through the darkness.

I don’t know.

I don’t know exactly how much time passed after I lost consciousness, or how many monsters I cut down in this place.

Truthfully, none of that mattered.

Looking back, I’d always been that kind of guy.

Like someone being chased, I’d race ahead with my eyes fixed forward, only to come to my senses somewhere I’d never expected.

And then—

I had to run again. Without even having time to look back.

I still don’t know the true name of the thing chasing so close that I can feel its breath on the back of my neck.

All I can do is cling with all my strength to a hope that seems ready to go out at any moment, and believe that if I take one more step—just one more—I’ll finally reach the end of this road.

Yeah.

Just like right now.

Shhhaaa.

Thousands of times. Tens of thousands.

No—more times than I could count.

As I repeated that familiar movement, an unnervingly low whistle ran along the spearhead slicing through the air.

The strike was precise and swift. The result it would bring was just as clear.

Shhk.

A slicing sound as familiar as the wind—and the sensation of death traveling up the shaft in my hands.

It’s over.

I was certain, and this time reality agreed.

Splash.

The enemy before me dropped to its knees in a pool of blood—or, by now, what would more accurately be called a stream.

But there was no groan of pain, no pleading look begging to survive.

The last Black Ghost stared at me with unfeeling eyes and said only this:

"—That person. Is waiting."

Like an actor carefully delivering every word of the line he'd been given.

"—For you, Jin Taekyung."

And that was all.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

> **System** - Mutated Gate **Forest of Death-I** successfully cleared! - You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP! - Level up! - All status ailments and fatigue have been recovered. - Gate-clearing conditions have been met.

A clear ringing sounded for me alone, and strength filled me once more. Beyond the fading mist, a field of magical power appeared in midair.

But neither Jeok Cheongang nor I reacted to any of the changes around us.

I looked at him. He looked silently at the Black Ghost that had met its end.

At the soulless shell of a boy who had once been someone's joy and reason for living.

Then, after a silence that was brief but felt long, Jeok Cheongang turned away.

"Damn it, what kind of place is this? I can't even tell how to get out. I feel like a lost child."

He grumbled as usual, but his voice was thick, as though soaked through. Somehow, I heard relief in it.

Or at least I wanted to.

For his sake.

I hoped the tremor in the voice that had said *I can finally let you go now* would ease, if only a little. The painful shudder I'd felt through my back, too.

This is enough.

If someone was facing and overcoming the pain they'd hidden inside all alone, then I could only believe that keeping my eyes closed for a moment had been the right choice.

A pillar was a reassuring support simply by being there. But it couldn't stand upright on its own.

"What are you waiting for? Get moving."

"Yes."

I smiled faintly and nodded.

"I'll lead the way."

We walked on together.

The place was still dark, covered in blood and corpses. But for some reason, it seemed a little brighter.

Chapter 1191

The only path connecting reality and a Gate.

The sensation of passing through a magical field was more than familiar to a veteran Hunter like me. Even so, it was often unpleasant enough to make me shudder.

Like now.

Whoooosh.

Was this what it felt like to be swept into a whirlpool?

The cold, sticky sensation of magical power wrapped around my entire body, then spat me out somewhere on the other side.

The moment I opened my eyes in the new space, I realized something I hadn't known before.

It's different.

Branches packed so tightly they covered the sky. Steep hills.

The mountains of corpses and rivers of blood that had filled every direction were gone.

But the scenery wasn't the only thing that had changed.

Magical power.

That filthy energy should have fallen away the moment I left the Gate. Instead, it was still clinging to my body.

No. It filled this entire space.

"This is…"

The words came out like a groan.

Jeok Cheongang, who had been shuddering at the magical field's repulsive sensation, reacted at once when I fell silent.

"What is it?"

Normally, I'd have laughed it off and said it was nothing.

But the intense sense of déjà vu pressing in on all five senses since the moment I opened my eyes brought back memories from less than a few weeks ago. And Jeok Cheongang already knew most of the truth about me.

"I've been somewhere like this before. Very recently, in fact."

"Ah. Could it be…?"

"Yes. The incident I told you about."

A gigantic mushroom cloud swallowing civilization. A metropolis with no trace of life.

And a being waiting for me in a dark castle newly raised above the blackened earth.

Morgoth.

That was it.

This place carried an energy remarkably like the Dragon Lair the Black Dragon Duke Morgoth had built atop the ruins of Moscow.

An energy intense enough that you could call it the Demon Realm.

No. It's even stronger.

According to Jeok Cheongang, I'd been unconscious for a little over a day.

I hadn't felt magical power this pure until I approached Morgoth's Dragon Lair. Here, power nearly as strong was already churning all around us.

So this is what the System meant by a restricted area.

Now I understood.

All kinds of absurd rumors floated around Murim, but if anything, the stories about this damn mountain range had understated the truth.

Now that I'd seen and felt the Tianshan Mountains for myself, I knew they were a forbidden land. A Land of Ruin.

Uninvited guests who hadn't received their master's permission shouldn't enter—and couldn't leave.

And this endless range of dark mountains showed no sign of revealing the secrets it hid within its vast bulk.

Not its master. Not the other uninvited guests besides Jeok Cheongang and me.

"I don't see the others."

"I suspected as much when that strange thing—whatever it was called—caught us. Seems I was right."

Jeok Cheongang narrowed his eyes at the mist drifting around us, but that didn't make the missing people suddenly appear.

Even a superhuman who could make out an ant over three hundred yards away couldn't peer through the space between reality and a Gate with human eyes.

…Right. That would be impossible.

Then a thought crossed my mind.

With human eyes.

I couldn't be sure this idea would work. Frankly, the odds favored me wasting my strength and making things worse.

But when there's only one path ahead—and you've already traveled it once—then no matter how huge an obstacle stands in the way, you have to smash through it and keep going.

Bzzzzzz.

The air began to tremble. I took a deep breath and raised my spearhead.

Slowly enough to make someone yawn, I spread the energy coiled within me through my entire body.

I felt Jeok Cheongang react to the move, but only for a moment. Then everything around me fell silent.

More precisely, my concentration reached its peak and shut out everything I didn't need, down to the slightest noise.

For one purpose alone.

To find the other spaces hidden behind the invisible veil.

And then—

Keeeeeng.

A ringing like thunder filled my ears. A terrible headache struck without warning, turning my vision white.

Ding.

Somewhere, a clear chime rang faintly. I knew my reckless attempt had succeeded—and that I couldn't let this fleeting opening slip away.

Drip. Drip.

Had the tiny blood vessels in my eyes burst one by one? Or was it the blood slipping between my lips without my noticing?

Everything I saw was red. Pain stabbed through my chest and brain.

It didn't matter.

I'd already seen it. Read it.

Cut.

I let out the breath I'd been holding and brought the spearhead slashing down from high above me.

Along the single path my other eye—the Mind's Eye—had shown me.

Shhhhaaa—

A blinding flash split the world. Split the invisible veil.

> **System** - Status effect **Trance** has ended.

That was the first line to appear before Jin Taekyung's eyes.

It was the signal flare. A signal flare announcing a wave of System notifications.

Ding. Beep.

> **System** - Special ability **Mind's Eye** has been activated because its activation conditions have been met! - Your insight into **Mind's Eye** has deepened. - Always exercise caution. This ability can cause severe harm to the user's mind and body, and in the worst case, can lead to death! - Status effect

> **Exhaustion** has been applied! - Status effect **Extreme Fatigue** has been applied! - Status effect **Internal Injury** has…

Jin Taekyung gasped for breath.

His chest felt tight. Nausea rose, and his disoriented body swayed from side to side.

Through vision warped like a heat haze, he saw Jeok Cheongang rush up to support him, shouting something. His battered senses could barely register the man's words or touch.

For a moment.

Then a second wave swept over him, accompanied by a cascade of chimes.

Ding. Ding. Ding.

> **System** - Mutated Gate **Forest of Death-II** destroyed! - Mutated Gate **Forest of Death-III** destroyed! - … - Mutated Gate **Forest of Death-VI** destroyed! - You have achieved the very rare achievement **Knock, and It Shall Be Opened**! - You have gained a tremendous amount of EXP as a reward for achieving a very rare achievement! - You have acquired the Title **Door Opener**! - Level up! - All injuries and fatigue have been recovered as a result of leveling up!

High risk, high reward.

The attempt had been dangerous, but the payoff was worth it.

He'd gained all at once the EXP it would take to defeat several Black Ghosts—and, more importantly, achieved his main goal.

"What on earth…!"

At his Master's stunned expression, the Disciple curled his bloodied lips into a smile.

"You can see for yourself."

The changes around them were already plain to the naked eye.

Grrrrk.

The empty air warped, like the face of a monster forced to spit something out.

And then—

Whoooosh.

Several previously invisible gaps opened their maws one after another.

They spilled out the darkness that had filled them, along with what they'd hidden away.

More precisely—

"Arrrgh! You sons of bitches—you're worse than beggars!"

“Come forth! I am Hyuk Mu—best hero the great Jin Family of Taiyuan has to offer!”

One beggar who didn’t hesitate to criticize himself, and one martial artist whose fierce loyalty to his family was matched only by his willingness to trade self-awareness for a piece of candy.

“…”

“…”

“…”

“…”

In the suffocating silence, the Jin Family of Taiyuan’s greatest hero finally spoke.

“Don’t be fooled, beggar. This is all their dark arts.”

The beggar, who was a little better than a son of a bitch, shot back.

“Do I look like an idiot who’d fall for this? I saw through this crap ages ago.”

“Heh. Just what I’d expect from the Beggars’ Sect’s Successor Beggar.”

“You’re not bad yourself. You figured it out right away.”

Master and Disciple watched them with distant eyes and had much the same thought.

Can’t we put those guys back?

Should I just put them back in?

Unfortunately, neither got the chance.

Before they could seriously consider how, a second rift opened.

Whoooosh.

Beyond the darkness fading away, a man appeared in a rush. His eyes were as cold as his expression as he surveyed the area, then asked Jin Taekyung,

“Dark arts?”

“This asshole’s at it too.”

At the answer that came without a pause, Song Ilseom lowered his blood-dripping blade.

“It’s really you.”

“Glad you’re alive. Where’s Young Lady Ju?”

“She’ll be out soon. It might’ve been a trap, so I went first.”

Song Ilseom hesitated, then added, “The employer’s safety comes first.”

“I didn’t ask— Ah, Young Lady Ju!”

“Benefactor! Great Hero Jin! Young Master Jin!”

Unlike the three before her, Ju Hwaran ran toward Jin Taekyung without the slightest hesitation.

More precisely, she would have—

If the third and fourth rifts hadn’t opened at the same time.

“Wow! I’ve never felt anything this gross before!”

Cheongpung emerged sounding remarkably cheerful for someone who’d just said that. Behind him, a shadow appeared like a ghost, as though it were one with the magical power. It acted without a word.

Shwack—CLANG!

A flash crossed the space faster than sound.

Jin Taekyung knocked aside the dagger flying at him with terrifying speed and shrugged.

“You could’ve just said something. Did you really have to go that far?”

“Assassins and physicians have a few things in common. Being suspicious of everything around us is one of them. The more we question, the fewer mistakes we make.”

“So, are you satisfied now?”

“I think I’m less suspicious of the reality I’m seeing, at least.”

The Slaughter Saint looked at Jin Taekyung with a curious glint in his eyes.

“I’m more suspicious of myself now, though. How did you wake up already?”

“Because you’re a quack.”

“Well, I’m nothing special. Anyone with the Heavenly Martial Physique and martial arts like mine could do it.”

“…”

The Slaughter Saint squeezed his eyes shut at the Master and Disciple’s mocking, arrogant answers. Just then, someone emerged from the fifth and final rift.

Unlike the others, she neither hurried nor moved stealthily. Not a drop of blood stained her clothes or skin.

But Bow Saint’s eyes were different from usual.

A tempest.

It lasted only a moment, but a few people saw it clearly: the traces of fierce emotion in eyes that were usually clear and unshakable.

Just as a wave striking a reef can’t hide its white foam, that emotion had left its mark somewhere in her eyes, black as the night sky.

Before anyone could form a clear suspicion about what they’d just seen, the low-voiced conversation between a beggar and a hero reached everyone’s ears.

“What? Is it real?”

“I told you it isn’t. Leave it to the Successor Beggar to talk like a filthy footwrap.”

“No, it looks real to me, no matter how I look at it.”

“I said it’s *real dark arts*.”

“Ha, shit. Is that so?”

Hyuk Mujin delivered the final blow to the frowning Gung Gibang.

“But dark arts can never be perfect. They grant power to those who abandon the proper path, but there’s always a flaw. Look—we’re one person short. They managed to imitate everyone else, but they must not have dared try that man.”

“…!”

“…!”

Everyone listening suddenly remembered something they’d forgotten.

Even now, after the final rift had closed, Great Sir was nowhere to be seen.